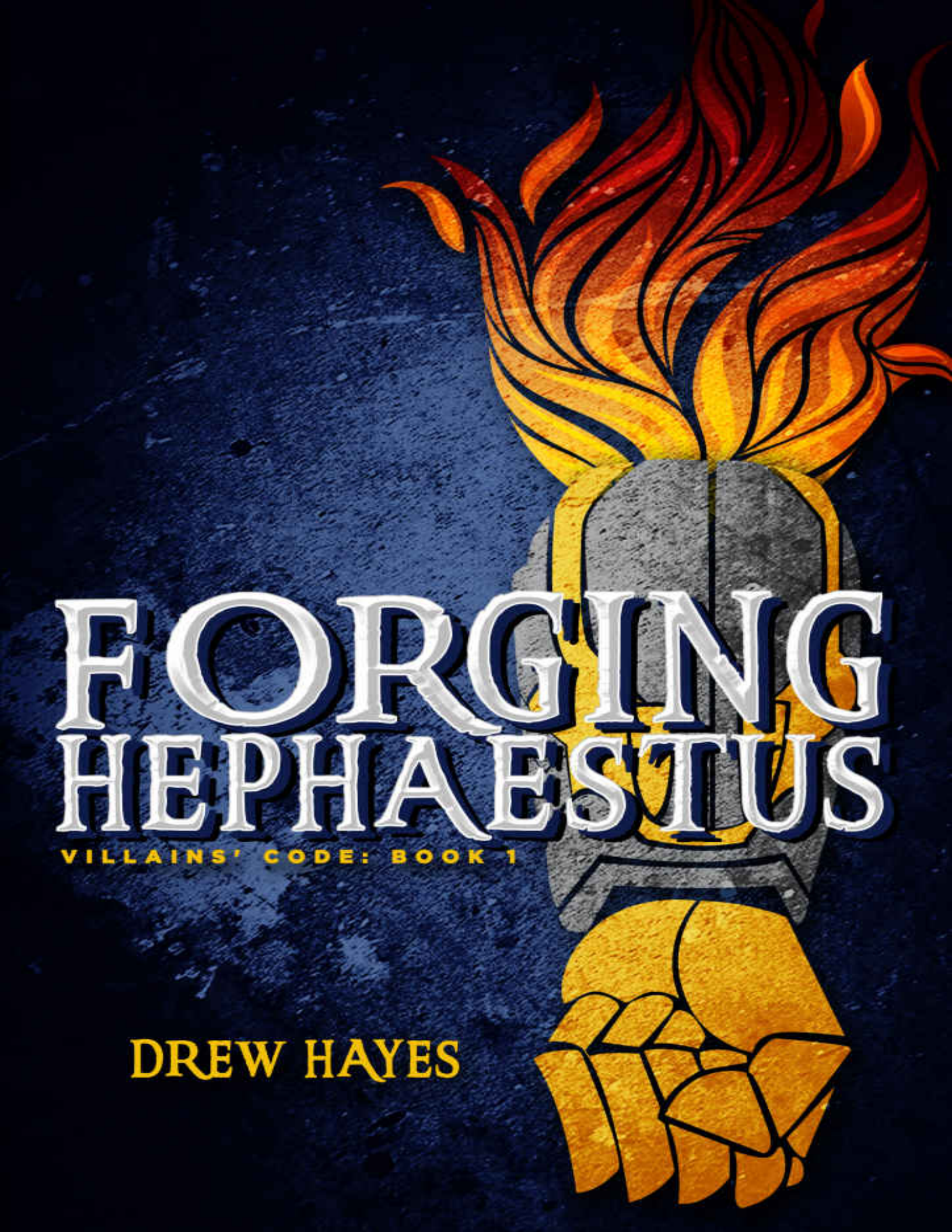




# FORGING HEPHAESTUS

VILLAINS' CODE: BOOK 1

DREW HAYES

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Villains' Code: Book 1

By Drew Hayes

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## Chapter 1

Flames cascaded down from the vent, moving like poured mercury rather than fire. They crackled as they danced through the air, drifting slowly to the steel floor. At first the fire seemed to shrink back from the cold metal surface upon contact, but as the steel began to glow from heat, the flames spread out. They twisted and curled upward into an elongated column. As they rose, a shape began to form. It started as a rough humanoid outline and became more human with each passing second, until it was clearly that of a young woman with long flowing hair. She would have looked quite normal, and perhaps a bit comely, were she not composed entirely of sentient flame.

Then, with no warning at all, the fire disappeared, and only the young woman remained. She turned her head with great care, taking in every detail of the vault that encased her.

It was a massive structure, one that had taken no less than three months of planning and two accomplices to break into, even with her special abilities. Lasers, alarms, pressure switches, heat sensors, and a myriad of cameras were just some of the obstacles she'd overcome, and now she was in their deepest sanctum.

No mere trinkets were housed in this tomb of titanium, no coins or jewels. No, this was a central vault for Indigo Technologies, a leader in every industry that involved circuits or switches. Everything they released managed to be years ahead of their competitors. With the prototypes and plans available here, she would be able to advance her own research by decades as well as make a tidy profit. Finally, she could begin funding her own projects. All it would take was a bit of corporate espionage to get her off the ground.

She stepped forward with impossible care, eyes sweeping for some new trap ready to spring out at her. None of her considerable bribes, thieving, or threats had secured her information about the vault's interior defenses, so from this point on she was flying blind. There was no way



Indigo would stop at merely protecting the outside, though, that much she was sure of. She crept toward one of the nearest walls, constantly on alert. When she reached it without incident, she tenderly opened the first drawer she could reach.

It was metallic, like all the box drawers she could see, and slid out from its nearly-seamless integration in the wall with a simple touch. The marking on its front—CX9-315—was gibberish to her, but she had to start the search somewhere. Perhaps she would get lucky and glean some sense of what the filing system meant from the box's contents, and if not, she would just keep searching blind.

Inside drawer CX9-315 was a single piece of paper. Clearly this project hadn't gotten very far off the ground, but if its mere concept was in a place this secure, then it had to be worth taking. She pulled the paper up to read it, unable to contain her curiosity. Curiosity was her fatal flaw, one that had resulted in her gaining her fire powers several years prior. But what met her eyes was not a project plan or a design schematic or even a rough sketch. Instead, it was two words in a bold, formal font, centered on the page:

**“Well Done”**

“The hell...?” she muttered, despite the fact that she was keenly aware of exactly what “the hell” was going on. Before she heard the vent system seal up or saw the glowing orbs crackling with energy rise from hidden compartments or felt the sudden dip in temperature—before all of that—she knew she was undone from the words alone. Someone had known she was coming, and Indigo Technologies was not the sort of company that failed to prepare for a guest appropriately.

“This is interesting,” said a new voice, one coming from everywhere in the room yet at the same time from no single spot. It was a male voice, older but not quite at the cusp of aged. Rather than sounding upset or accusing, it seemed amused. That, more than anything else, set her teeth on edge. Angry people could be predicted; their actions would fall in the realm of reason. Someone amused, sounding like they'd found a new toy, could herald true horrors in store for her.

“Did you know that when we set this little trap for you, I was the only one who believed you had the skills to spring it? Everyone else thought you’d be snared by the lasers or the coolant cannons. Only I believed you had what it would take to make it all the way here.”

“Trying to make me feel thankful?” She held the paper firmly in hand and it burst into flames. The fire spread up her hand to her elbow; within seconds there was nothing left but ash. Undone or not, she had no intention of going down gently.

“None of that, now. I was trying to tell you that you’ve just won me several thousand dollars and bragging rights. This means at the moment I am rather predisposed to like you, while my underlings are significantly miffed. You should probably just go along with things, because the other options in front of you are far less pleasant.”

At his words, the temperature in the vault dropped noticeably. She suspected that if she’d had a normal tongue and pressed it to the metal walls, it would have stuck. Maintaining her flames grew significantly more difficult, but she persevered. She would not show weakness, not even if that was her final act of defiance.

“All things considered, if I have to die, then I think I’d like to wreck as many of your toys as I can on my way out,” she spat.

“Die? Who on earth mentioned dying? Dear child, this is an opportunity.”

“You just called it a trap.” The flames spread farther along her arms even as the temperature continued to drop.

“It’s that too. A trap, an opportunity, and an audition. We’ve had an eye on you for some time, Tori Rivas. We wanted to see just what you were capable of, given a bit of information and some competent cronies.”

“Geraldine and Cooper... they work for you? You set this whole thing up?”

“We gave you resources; you’re the one who decided how to use them. And to that effect, you used them very well. Breaking into this vault is no small feat; we designed it not to be.”

“Why go to all this trouble? Why didn’t you just approach me with a grant or a job offer?” Tori asked, looking up at the ceiling vaguely since there was no physical person to direct her questions toward. “Indigo Technologies is huge and well-funded, I’d have taken a job.” Well, she’d have pretended to accept, and then used her access to find a much easier way into the vault, at any rate.

“Oh, Ms. Rivas, there is so very much to bring you up to speed on. Suffice it to say that we wanted to test far more than your ability to punch a clock and boil some coffee. Plus, we’re well aware of your opinion toward conventional occupations. At any rate, I’d love to continue this discussion; however, you have yet to make a decision.”

“A decision about what?” Her voice leapt and the fire flashed on her arms. Cold could dampen the physical capabilities of her power, but it held no dominion over the temper burning inside her.

“About your future. You are smart, talented, determined, and powerful. We have taken notice of you and of your potential. At this point, there are two ways we can regard you: as an asset or a threat. Assets are tempered, trained, and cultivated. Threats are eliminated.”

“Do it then, call the capes! Let’s see you explain your little mousetrap to them when they come get me. I’m sure some of the shit in here is illegal.”

“I did not say threats were incarcerated. I said threats were *eliminated*.”

The floating orbs glowed more brightly. The temperature had fallen well below freezing. It would be impossible to fully transform in here now, and obviously her captor knew it.

“You can’t do this. You’re just a corporation; you don’t get to kill whoever you want.”

“A better grasp of America’s history in third-world nations and its handling of union debacles would tell you just how wrong that statement is in general. But let’s focus on the point that’s most salient to our discussion:

we are far from *just* a corporation. Talking time is done, Ms. Rivas. You have a choice to make.”

Tori stared at the orbs, wondering if she could take them out. As cold as it was, she rather doubted it, but anything was possible. One never knew how a fight would end until it was over, that’s what her father had always taught her. Still, even if she took out the orbs, they were bound to have other things, worse things, waiting in the wings. She didn’t want to go down easily... but she also didn’t want to die.

The flames on her arms burned away, leaving behind a woman who seemed far smaller and more frightened than she had only seconds before.

“Does anyone ever take the other option?” Tori asked, as she watched the orbs vanish back into the walls.

“More than you might think. Our kind is a stubborn, prideful lot, and many do not take well to being trapped and threatened.”

“Our kind?”

The vault door opened, revealing a tall man in his mid- to late-forties, adorned in meta-armor Tori recognized at once. How could she not? It belonged to one of the most famous inventors of the last hundred years and one of the greatest criminals the world had ever seen. It had taken at least ten capes, working in tandem, to finally take him down. All that was missing was his trademark helmet, which was why Tori could make out the blue eyes and surprisingly warm smile on his face as he answered her question.

“Villains, Ms. Rivas. That is our kind. We are villains.”

\* \* \*

“Take that, vile monster! I smite thee with the shining light of justice!”

Clacking filled the air as thin, dexterous fingers danced along the keyboard and caused the shining knight on the screen to hack and slash with furious gusto. Each move was precise and calculated, decimating the wicked minotaur’s health faster than the bull-headed being could recover.



Victory seemed certain, until a gentle but very deliberate cough filled the air.

“Donald, what are you doing? We’ve talked about this before.”

Donald spun around in his chair, one of the few orthopedic ones in the office, until his eyes rested on the tall man staring down at him. Ivan wore his usual pressed dark suit, crisp white shirt, and knotted red tie as he looked at his employee with a mix of weary exasperation and subtle displeasure.

“I’m just playing a game, Mr. Gerhardt. I didn’t break the rules like before. It’s my lunch break, and I brought my laptop from home, so I didn’t think it would be an issue.”

Ivan carefully considered the gangly young man in front of him. He could come down hard on Donald, scare the wits out of the poor boy so that he’d never step out of line again, but that would probably put him off working here. Despite his... *tendencies*, Donald was a talented programmer. Even with his knack for getting lost in side projects, he seldom missed a deadline, and the work he produced always ranged from good to excellent. Most managers would say that such things were irrelevant, that rules were rules and had to be followed. Ivan had been managing for some time, though, and he knew that cultivating resources was more important than being authoritarian. Besides, he had a bit of a soft spot for rule-breakers, as long as they stayed within the bounds that *he* set.

“Putting an unauthorized computer on the network violates several of Vendallia Industries’ safety protocols,” Ivan said at last. “That thing could have all manner of viruses, and without the safety software we put on the corporate machines, there would be no way to tell.” This was bullshit, pure and simple. The corporate machines had cookie-cutter software that was easy enough for the management to use and cheap enough for the higher-ups to justify. Someone with Donald’s skills undoubtedly had a more secure laptop than what the rest of the office was working on.

“Oh, right. I didn’t think about that,” Donald said. Ivan could see he was lying; even a man without his background could have read the anxious young man’s face.

“Look, it’s a silly rule, but if IT catches wind of you putting that thing on the network, we’ll both get an earful. Do you really like playing games that much?”

“It just helps me relax, reset my head. I don’t want to cause trouble, but this is sort of like my equivalent to a smoke break,” Donald said.

Ivan nodded empathetically; it was a skill he’d spent years honing to get just right. “I can understand that. But at the same time, I can’t let you break safety protocol. So here’s what I’d like to propose: you’re on the Elquey Project, right?”

“Yes sir, Mr. Gerhardt.”

“That’s a big project with a lot of money to be made, so the people up top are keeping a close eye on it. I need someone I can trust watching over the technical side. And Donald, I think you might be the man for that job.”

“Me?” Donald’s brown eyes widened, stretching so far that for a moment it seemed his eyebrows would make contact with the ends of his stringy red hair.

“That’s right, Donald, you. That’s what I came to talk about. I’ve had my eye on you for months, and I think this is your time to shine.” Ivan carefully rested a hand on the wall of the cubicle, being sure to present body language that spoke to how open and caring he was. “The whole department needs this to go well, and I’m a firm believer in the right man for the right job. Part of that job, by the way, will entail needing a personal company laptop. You’d have to use it for all manner of work, and you’d be free to install anything on it, so long as it meets the company’s general use guidelines.” Ivan doubted Donald was stupid enough to watch porn on a company computer, but he also didn’t want to have IT yelling at him about another hard drive caked in smut.

“So... I could play games on it?”

“When you’re not on company time, yes, so long as they’re not inappropriate, you’d be free to use the device as you saw fit. Now tell me, are you interested in the position, or do I move on to Williams?”

Donald's wide eyes suddenly narrowed. He and Rene Williams hadn't gotten along since they started. Rene was a ruthless kissass who never hesitated to steal credit or throw others under the bus. Ivan might have been inclined to reward such behavior if Rene also had the skills to succeed without others to feed upon. As it was, his main purpose was as a motivational tool Ivan could wield against his other employees. The moral and decent didn't want to see Rene Williams make any headway in the company, so much so that they would often take on extra tasks to prevent it.

"No sir, Mr. Gerhardt. I want the job. Please."

"Excellent, I'm glad to hear it. I'll put in the form this afternoon. By Thursday, you should be approved. Oh, and I'm sure it goes without saying, but no more breaking protocol. You understand that this is a big opportunity and a lot of eyes will be upon you, right?"

"Yes, sir."

"Good man, glad to hear it. Just send me an e-mail if you have any questions." Ivan turned and strode out of the cubicle, an expression of genuine happiness on his face.

Whatever manipulative methods he might have used to get his way, Ivan had meant what he said: Donald really was the best man for the job. He was talented, smart, and resourceful, not to mention so terrified of authority that Ivan wouldn't have to put forth much effort to keep him in line. That would make Ivan's job, and therefore his life, easier.

He strode into his office—nothing too fancy, just four walls and a door that closed—and sat down at his desk. His computer had gone to sleep while he made his rounds, the dark screen showing his reflection instead of the spreadsheet program he'd left running. Ivan wasn't particularly handsome, though he did appeal to women who liked strong noses and pronounced chins. Both his eyes and hair were quite dark, a feature he'd inherited from his mother and passed on to one of his two children. Despite his age, Ivan looked like he couldn't be much older than his late twenties, a fact that everyone inevitably brought up when they met him.

There were a myriad of lies he used to explain the phenomenon: clean living, regular exercise, liberal use of sunscreen, and excellent

genetics all making regular appearances. Soon, though, he'd have to think of something else—looking like this in his early forties was one thing, but once he was in his fifties, genuine suspicion would be aroused. Perhaps he'd lie and say he'd been doused with an experimental anti-aging serum. It would be strange, but not altogether unbelievable. It was certainly a far cry better than telling them the real reason his body refused to stop being youthful and fit.

Ivan glanced down at his desk and noticed the red voicemail indicator on his cell phone blinking. That was curious. Even down the hall, he should have heard his ringtone; that's why he'd felt comfortable leaving the phone in the first place. Picking up the device, he unplugged it from its charger (damn thing could never last more than half a day) and pressed the button to call his voicemail.

As soon as he heard the voice on the other end, everything made sense. Of course the actual calling process had been bypassed. The message probably wasn't even sent from another phone... more likely a convoluted system meant to bounce around signals and scramble listening devices. Ivan would have dismissed it as paranoia, if not for the fact that his friend had excellent reasons to be suspicious of prying ears. With a resolved grunt, Ivan leaned back in his own chair and listened to the message.

*"Ivan, it's Wade. There's something I'm going to need your help with. Not the usual kind either. We've got a... well, I'll tell you in person tonight. This is me letting you know I'm coming over, so don't try and kill me as soon as I walk on your lawn or anything. See you soon."*

Ivan set the phone back down and shook his head. One time, one time he'd almost killed Wade, and the man had never let him live it down. You break into someone's lair in the middle of the night, and you can't be surprised when they take a swing at you.

Especially not when that person had a reputation like Ivan's.

## Chapter 2

Ivan lived in a two-story ranch-style house in a suburb of Ridge City. It looked exactly like six other houses in his neighborhood, save for the fact that Ivan had selected the beige trim while the others had gone with eggshell. It was a four bedroom, with one for Ivan, one that served as a home office, and the remaining two were for each of his children. Those were only in use every other weekend, but he liked to have a place for them to feel at home when they came over. In the front was a small patio adorned with a couple of wooden rocking chairs that looked homemade but had actually been purchased at a local chain store. Between them was a table in the same style, upon which there was a glass of iced tea waiting for Ivan as he stepped outside.

The heat of summer was dying out, giving way slightly to the brisk nip of fall. The battling elements made the evenings perfect for sitting out—enough heat to be warm paired with just the right amount of breeze to stay cool. As Ivan sipped his tea, he gave a polite nod to Mrs. Jefferson, the elderly neighbor who was making the trek down her driveway to check her mail. She was a sweet woman, likely a bit too frail to be living alone, but she refused to let a little thing like that stop her. Ivan and the other neighbors pitched in to help with her yard work and keep up her house. The others did so out of good-heartedness and likely a concern for property values if one home became derelict, and Ivan because he had a healthy respect for people who refused to do what they were expected to, even if it came at the cost of their own health.

A silver sedan pulled into Ivan's driveway, a familiar copper-haired man behind the wheel. Ivan was grateful that Wade had come in a normal car; heaven knew the billionaire had more than enough luxury automobiles to turn heads on this humble little street. Instead he was driving a nice, but not ostentatious, car that blended in perfectly with the neighborhood. Of course, knowing Wade, that vehicle was probably rocket-proof, could fly, and had a button that turned it into a robot. But so long as all that stayed hidden, it wasn't any of Ivan's concern.

The engine died and Wade emerged. Unlike Ivan, he was wearing his years appropriately. Though still tall and lean, a small pooch of belly had begun to accumulate around his midsection, no doubt the result of all-nighters filled with eating terrible junk food. His shiny copper hair was thinning, and within another decade, he'd likely be bald on top—unless he spared a day or so to find a cure. His eyes were still the same, blue and wild and full of life, barely able to contain all the thoughts of the brain behind them. He strolled up the driveway toward the walkway, avoiding Ivan's well-maintained lawn. Despite his wealth, or perhaps because of it, Wade always wore a similar outfit when he was going “mundane”: jeans, custom shoes that supported his poor arches, and a plaid button-down.

“Evening,” Ivan said, greeting his friend and one of the oldest acquaintances he had.

“Evening,” Wade replied, settling down in the unoccupied rocking chair.

“Can I get you something to drink?”

“Maybe in a bit. How's life at the office treating you?” As Wade spoke, he pulled a small silver box from his pocket. It looked a lot like an oversized lighter, but as with everything else with Wade, looks were incredibly deceiving.

“Could be worse. At least the shitty economy means I've got a glut of qualified people desperate for work. Beats the hell out of the days when we were snagging any kid who could string three lines of code together.” Ivan took a drink of cold iced tea, enjoying the excessive sweetness. He made his the old-fashioned way, with enough sugar to cause diabetes in a single glass. Life had taken away many of his vices, but this was one he refused to let go of. Besides, it wasn't as though a thing like sugar could hurt his body.

“Bad economy means it's an employer's market.” Wade finished fiddling with his box; a small red light ignited near the base. He set it on the table, a safe distance away from Ivan's tea, and continued. “Okay, that should do it.”



“I remember when you needed a room the size of my house and machines as big as your car to create your Cone of Silence.”

“I don’t care how much you liked *Get Smart* as a kid, we’re not calling it that. It’s a portable sound isolation and management system.”

“Yes, your version just rolls off the tongue,” Ivan said. He made sure to keep his usual half-smile on his face as he spoke. Wade’s device would stop all forms of technological eavesdropping they’d discovered, not to mention distort the movements of their lips to prevent reading, and Ivan had wards all over his property that halted scrying, but none of that would stop people from noticing if they suddenly hunched over and acted secretive. The best way to do nefarious things was right out in the open, as if you had nothing to hide. “Now that we’re cloaked and you’re here, tell me what the big news is. I can’t already be up in rotation.”

“No, your work last month was superb; however, it left the others a bit uneasy about calling on your services again.”

“That’s what I was going for,” Ivan replied.

“Clearly. The blood on the ceiling made that point abundantly obvious. I’m here about a different matter. Last week we picked up a new candidate: smart, willful, and with a power that she’s barely scratched the surface of. The rest of the board agrees with me that she has tremendous potential, but... well, I did say she was willful, didn’t I?”

“Yes, you did.”

“Very much so. She’s not taking direction well, keeps bucking against us, toeing the line just enough not to fall out of our good graces completely. Some feel she’ll never make the grade and we’re better off cutting our losses. That there’s no point in training a future code-breaker.”

Ivan knew all too well what Wade was hinting at, and he was glad he’d made such a spectacle of his last job. He’d do his part, but he preferred that people be scared to call him in. It meant they wouldn’t try to use him as some go-to exterminator.

“Personally,” Wade continued, “I feel such actions are extreme and unnecessary at this point, but if things don’t change, then sooner or later,

that will be the unavoidable outcome. That's why I contacted you. Standard training isn't working for her, so I thought she might benefit from the old way we learned: master and apprentice."

"Hold the damn phone," Ivan said, setting down his tea so hard a bit sloshed over the side. "Look, I do what's necessary when I have to, but there is no way I'm going fully back in. Getting joint custody was hard enough; if I get busted, even if we beat it, I'll be lucky to see my kids before they graduate college."

"Calm down, no one is asking you to come back," Wade assured him. "This would be a modified program. No crime necessary on your part. You'd be a mentor: taking her under your wing and teaching her how things work. The rules, how to fight, picking targets, all the theory and legal training. Any real outings will be done by someone else with you in a supervisory capacity at the most."

Ivan settled back in his chair and plastered the fake smile back on his face, but the scowl in his eyes never quite lessened. "Fine, so I wouldn't have to go back in. Why should I do it, though? There are plenty of qualified people in your organization. Hell, you could do it yourself. I'm sure she'd love to study under the great Doctor Mechaniacal."

"Sure she would, and the minute I turned my back, she'd either try and steal everything off my hard drive or roast it when she failed. The woman is too smart and ambitious to trust around my lab. Luckily she's all science-minded, no talent or capacity for magic. Means you'd have nothing to worry about."

"Still not explaining why you need me instead of the others. Arcanicus has got to be bored as hell lately, and he's all magic too," Ivan pointed out.

"Look, I'll level with you: she's kind of a pain in the ass. Lots of us could try and train her, but no one wants to. Potential aside, they just don't see her being worth the investment of time and energy to properly mold. Add in the fact that a few folks are probably legitimately scared of her and it creates a pupil without a suitable teacher, save possibly for you."

"Why me?"

“Because you’re a pain in the ass too,” Wade replied. There was nothing accusatory in his statement; he told this to Ivan the same way he’d have given him the time. “You’re stubborn, temperamental, willful, and you scare the shit out of a lot of members. Near as I can see, you’re either the perfect teacher for her, or you’ll kill her in two days. Either outcome solves my problem.”

The prospect was certainly interesting, and Ivan could probably do with a new project. His last one, wood-working, had ended in a summer bonfire and a trip to purchase the rocking chairs he and Wade were sitting in. Still, an apprentice was a lot of work, and a fair amount of responsibility. It had the potential to complicate the life he’d worked so hard to keep nice and serene.

“I’ll accept that I might be a good fit for her,” Ivan said. “But that doesn’t tell me why I should do it. I’m not the altruistic sort, you know.”

“So you claim,” Wade chuckled. He was one of the few people who knew all of Ivan’s sides, the dark and the light. Admittedly, there was ample darkness, but he wasn’t an empty monster. At least, not unless he had reason to be. “I already discussed it with the training board, and we decided that a stipend would be appropriate compensation for your troubles.”

“My job pays fine, as you ought to know, so thanks, but no thanks.”

“Fine, sure, but doesn’t Rick start applying to college in a few years?”

“Janet and I have a college fund for both him and Beth.”

Wade shook his head. “Ivan, you’re missing the offer. Rick is a bright boy, and Beth is no slouch either, but with their current grades and extracurriculars, they’re looking at a good state college, maybe a bit higher if they do very well on their SATs. I’m offering guaranteed, fully-paid, top-tier admission. Literally, pick a school, and they’ll get accepted with a full ride. Rick wants to work for NASA, right? The Ivy League certainly wouldn’t look bad on his resume.”

“Malphorus came up with this, didn’t he? I educate yours, you educate mine; it has the sort of symmetry he loves.”

“It was his suggestion, but I thought the compensation would pique your interest. You’ve already earned a good, stable life for yourself. I assumed you’d be more inclined to help your children get closer to theirs.”

From anyone else, Ivan would have taken this as manipulation, and his reaction would not have been kind. Wade was a friend, however, and in their former occupation, friends were a rare thing. He was truly looking out for Ivan, offering him something that would be unattainable through normal means. Wade was using his knowledge of what Ivan loved to create a better deal, not to try and con him into accepting against his better judgment. And, if Ivan were being honest with himself, it would take a lot of worry off his shoulders to know his children were getting a good first step into the adult world.

“I guess I can at least see what she’s got,” Ivan conceded at last. “No promises, though. If I don’t think I can teach her, I’m walking away.”

“That’s what I’d want you to do anyway,” Wade said. “I can take you to her now, if you’re ready.”

“In a minute.” Ivan reached over and picked up his glass. “First, I want to finish my tea.”

\* \* \*

The skeleton let out a pathetic wail as the fireball struck its ribcage, exploding and shattering it into dozens of pieces. Nearby, another skeleton was caught by surprise as its target unleashed a torrent of flame that caused its bones to blacken and crack and shortly become too frail to hold together. More skeletons marched up to fill the ranks of their fallen brothers. They were many, but their opponent was strong. Strong... and dangerous.

“Almost makes me feel bad for the things,” Ivan said, staring at the monitor as another trio of skeletons was taken out.

“She’s able to destroy them nearly as fast as Arcanicus can conjure them,” Wade said. On another monitor, they could see an older man, probably a decade ahead of Wade, wearing robes and weaving magical symbols in the air. Every couple of seconds, the symbols would form together and a new skeleton would appear in front of him. The man would

point to a door, and the skeleton would totter through to its fiery destruction.

“Not much thought behind her moves,” Ivan commented. “She’s just throwing fireballs and blast streams. They’re good range attacks, but what about up close?”

“I’d wager that’s why she’s in her fire-form,” Wade replied.

Tori was indeed composed entirely of flames. She looked more like a tall inferno that happened to be human shaped than a woman who had changed her molecular chemistry.

“It’s a potent ability, not overwhelming in strength, but with lots of versatility,” Ivan said. “The guild seriously wants to be done with her so soon?”

Wade nodded, the gesture a bit stiff and weary. “Smart and strong as she is, Tori has also been steadily refusing to take her education seriously. We try and teach her about strategy, secrecy, and of course the code, but she keeps digging in her heels. From what I’ve gathered, she spent the last decade or so subsisting off of petty crime and a network of other crooks. Most of the ones pulled in to teach her feel she’s too far gone, that all we’re doing right now is strengthening a future code-breaker. And I don’t have to tell you what the guild’s policy on that is.”

That subject was one that Ivan knew too well, perhaps even better than Wade. Useful power or not, if she seemed like a danger to the guild, then the threat would be neutralized. There was nothing else to say on the matter, so Ivan politely changed the subject.

“You’re sure she’s all science? I’ve never met a full-phase shifter without at least a little magic helping the process.”

“Positive. It was an accident, so she’s not certain how to recreate it, but the fact remains that Tori Rivas found a way to turn into sentient fire.”

The two men were standing in a small office not far from the training facility where Tori was going through her daily combat training. They weren’t in the guild’s proper headquarters—aside from concerns about the length of her tenure, no one felt comfortable having people with

powers test their limits in the same place where files and servers were stored. This was a training facility set up behind a secret door in what was, for the most part, a pork rendering plant. The smell alone was enough to keep all but the most determined of parties away.

“The power is impressive, sure, but with how she’s using it, she’d never get above Delta Class. Just having Arcanicus switch to flaming skeletons would be enough to render her whole attack strategy useless.”

“I told you that she had potential, not that she was ready to go,” Wade reminded him. “If she were already adept and skilled, then your tutelage wouldn’t be necessary.”

“I guess. Does she just have the fire-shifting or did she get anything else?”

“She heals at a rapid rate, even more so when given time to shift between phases. Her body is tougher than a human’s, though nothing approaching your level, and her basic speed and strength are augmented as well. What really shines through, however, is her intellect. The clothes she was wearing when the exercise started, the ones that phased with her? She made those herself. Invented a process all on her own with no funds or facility to speak of. The woman has a strong education, a bright mind, and a, forgive the phrase, burning ambition.”

Ivan nodded and kept his eyes on the monitor. Creating fabric that could shift phases wasn’t unheard of, but the rarity of needing it and complexity in making it meant that phasing outfits were very expensive. Like most meta-tech, it was rare and hard to buy, unless you were the one making it. That she’d managed to create some without any resources did speak to a smart mind, but not so brilliant of one that Ivan understood his friend’s interest in this woman.

“Be straight with me here, Wade. What’s the deal? Is she the daughter of some guy in the guild who wants his kid in the business, or related to a cape that we’re trying to stick it to by turning family, or something along those lines? She’s got potential, I’ll give you that, but I don’t know that she has enough to warrant all the special treatment.”

“What’s the deal?” Wade repeated, his eyes never darting away from the monitors. He lifted a long finger and pointed to the image on the screen. “Arcanicus won’t be able to keep pumping out skeletons for much longer. He’s already beginning to sweat.” Sure enough, the robed man was red-faced as he continued weaving magic and conjuring animated bones from nothingness. “I remember when he could curse a continent without so much as getting winded. Age is beginning to take him, as it will eventually take almost all of us.” Wade shot his friend a targeted glance on the word “almost,” and Ivan pretended not to notice.

“So, what, you want a successor? Then you should train her.”

“It’s not about an individual successor. It’s about the impact we leave on the next generation. Some of the new members are hungry for violence and blood; they weren’t around to see how bad things can get when we make war with the capes. Even Balaam, though appointed to the guild’s council, constantly tries to move for amendments that would allow our members more freedom for carnage.”

“There are always a few who want to go back to the old ways. We have a system for code-breakers,” Ivan said. He didn’t enjoy the system or his occasional role in it, but that didn’t change the fact that it had to be there.

“But if enough like Balaam rise through the ranks, they can change the code. Rewrite it, strip it of meaning, and destroy the tenuous peace we’ve been able to create. I want more in our ranks like her: concerned with freedom over violence, someone who embraces this life because they refuse to bow down instead of wanting to cut others to their knees.”

“Save it for the poetry slam. I get your point.” Ivan looked at Tori once more, watching her tear through the last of the skeletons in the room. “You really think she can be someone we count on?”

“If she’s taught properly, I know it,” Wade said.

“Then I guess I should go meet her and see for myself. Tell Arcanicus to clear out. I’m administering her next test.”

“I suspect he’ll be overjoyed for the break,” Wade replied. “Dare I ask what this test will be?”

“I’m going to see if she’s got what it takes to learn under me,” Ivan said. He gently stretched his arms behind his back, noting the rogue popping sounds from various joints. “Fair warning, though: either she passes her entrance exam or it will probably kill her. That going to be an issue?”

“No problem at all.”

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## Chapter 3

The metal doors whispered open, but this time it wasn't more pathetic skeletons tottering through. Doctor Mechaniacal walked in instead, side by side with some guy who looked closer to Tori's age. She wondered if she'd have to fight this one too. She really hoped not: combat wasn't why she'd agreed to this training, and besides, aside from being fit, the new guy didn't seem exceptionally powerful. Not that looks meant much when dealing with meta-humans.

Ivan noticed the appraising look she gave him and kept his own expression neutral. From her body language, she'd drawn all the wrong conclusions about him. That didn't particularly bother Ivan; in fact, he took it as a compliment. He worked very hard to maintain his mundane facade. Her inability to see through it was just a testament to how effective it was. Of course, that wouldn't excuse the mistakes she was bound to make, but Ivan felt complimented all the same.

"Doctor," she said, keeping her tone flat but respectful. "I hope you're here to tell me I'm done fighting skeletons."

"Learning to deal with multiple opponents is an important aspect of training," Wade told her. "Though you could stand to work on your delicacy."

"If I'm fighting a room full of people, delicacy is going to be the last thing on my mind."

"That statement there sums up why you need to work on it," Ivan said. Tori was a bit surprised at the authority in his voice. He spoke with the sort of confidence and power she associated with older, more established people. "When you've got a room full of people coming for you, that's exactly when you should be delicate, not explosive."

"Explosive seemed to work just fine." Tori gestured to the fading bits of bone in the room. Most had already turned back into the mystic ether

from which they were sculpted, but a few fragments were still dotting the floor.

“And if you’re in a room with allies?” Ivan asked, stepping over a fading chunk of skull. Arcanicus’s constructs tended to stain if one stepped on them while they dissolved, and these were new shoes.

“I’m sorry, aren’t you all a bunch of villains? I didn’t really think I’d need to learn about how to play on a team.”

“Then you’re even more foolish than I first suspected,” Ivan said. “Of course we work together. The very existence of this guild should demonstrate that concept to you quite thoroughly.” He turned to Wade, who was somehow managing to keep a cheerful grin fixed firmly in place. “You’re really sure about this woman?”

“She has potential,” Wade replied simply.

“She also has ears and doesn’t like being talked about as if she isn’t in the room.” Tori glared at both of them for a moment then directed the bulk of her ire to Ivan. “Doctor Mechaniacal gets a pass out of respect for what he’s accomplished, but I’ve got no inclination to take any shit off of you, Khakis.”

“Actually, I’m the most important person in the world, so far as you’re concerned,” Ivan said, “because I’m the one who decides if you live to see another sunrise or not. The guild is thinking about terminating your association with them, but Doctor Mechaniacal has persuaded them to let you stay on as an apprentice. Of course, any apprentice needs a teacher, and that’s what he’s trying to rope me into doing.”

“You’re full of it,” Tori snapped.

“No, everything he’s said is perfectly true.” Wade didn’t even bother to look ashamed. To him, the situation was a purely practical one; there was no need to get caught up in sentiment over it. “You must have realized your attitude and refusal to cooperate would have consequences. Many of my colleagues feel you can’t be made useful, and they advocate ending this experiment before you become too troublesome.”

“Too... troublesome?” For the first time since Ivan had laid eyes on her, uncertainty flickered across Tori’s face. Her eyes darted from him, to Wade, and back to him, repeating this cycle several times before she found her words. “Okay, maybe I haven’t been a perfect little student, but it’s not like I asked to join you guys in the first place.”

“What you asked for is irrelevant. You’re here, this is the situation. Standard training is clearly a lost cause. You’ll either leave this room as an apprentice, or not at all,” Wade said.

“Then be my teacher! You’re the one I want to learn from, anyway. Please, help me out here.”

“He’s already convinced people who aren’t easily swayed to give you another chance,” Ivan interrupted. “Doctor Mechanial is the reason you ever got this opportunity at all, so be grateful for what he’s done.”

“But—”

“There are no buts.” Ivan had crossed the room and was now close enough to feel the heat radiating off his prospective student. Either she was upset or just pissed; either way she was unconsciously cranking up the temperature. If he took her as a student, her first lessons would be on control. “I’ve been chosen to teach you. If I accept the job, then you get to prove Doctor Mechanial was right by not doing anything to make me have to kill you.”

Tori stared at him for a few moments, emotions flickering through her eyes as she tried to make sense of a suddenly life-threatening situation. For the briefest of seconds, Ivan thought she would settle on panic, or worse, fear, but she pulled herself together and her eyes grew hard. She was letting anger carry her through this. It wasn’t a bad call, provided she could keep it wrangled.

“Fine. So you’re here to decide if I’m teachable, is that it? Then what do I have to do to prove that I’m worth the effort? I can roast skeletons all day, if that’s your cup of tea.”

Ivan shook his head. “No, I don’t think that will be necessary. All I want you to do is survive a single punch from me. That’s your test.”

Tori tilted her head, ever so slightly. “Survive a punch? That’s it? I guess I have to stay in human-form then.”

“You can be fire if you want to,” Ivan said. “You can also try to dodge or avoid it. I’m only throwing the one punch, so if you succeed, you pass. I’ll even tell you where I’m hitting you: it’s going to be dead center in your torso, right through your sternum.”

“Is this for real?” Tori looked over at Wade, who gave her a small nod. “You know that when I’m in fire-form, physical attacks can’t hurt me.”

“I have things to do today. Let’s move this along.” Ivan took a few steps back and cocked his right fist back. “Take your time and get set. Let me know when you’re ready, and that’s when I’ll punch.”

Tori wasn’t sure what to make of this strange man with dark hair and seemingly unwarranted confidence, but she was smart enough to take an associate of Doctor Mechanical’s seriously. Her skin grew warm, then red, and then vanished completely as her entire form shifted to that of animated flame. She retained a humanoid shape for the moment; giving him a torso to aim at meant his moves would be easier to anticipate. Her fiery feet slid back along the floor as Tori braced herself, prepared to move in a heartbeat. After taking a few seconds to make sure there was nothing else she could do, Tori realized she was stalling. It was now or never.

“Ready.” Her voice sounded like a fireplace crackling with fresh logs, but the words were still enunciated perfectly. Her attention was on the curious man in the khakis; she was ready to react the instant he moved.

It was this concentration that saved her life. In the sliver of an instant between when Ivan closed the gap between them and slammed his fist into her torso, Tori sensed the slightest movement. Acting on instinct more than strategy, she shifted a few millimeters back, turning his strike into a glancing blow instead of a direct one. She expected something strange to happen, for his hand to hurt when it went through her or for him to display a burst of cold powers.

What she hadn’t counted on or imagined, not even for an instant, was that his fist would hit her as solidly as if she were still flesh and blood. She flew backward and crashed into the far wall; her form was undone as

soon as she struck, leaving her little more than a flaming puddle smeared against the steel wall. She was in more pain than she'd ever experienced in this form, but Tori was still conscious. That meant she was alive.

"How... how..." Her voice crackled from the slowly reforming mass of fire; she was barely able to string words together.

Ivan, to his credit, kept his word and didn't throw another attack. Instead he just stared, watched her carefully through eyes that no longer belonged to Ivan the manager. These eyes were almost entirely black, aside from a series of runes burning from the center of each eye. Though the eyes didn't belong to Ivan the manager, they did belong to another identity of Ivan's, one he hadn't used for many years.

Tori finished pulling herself together and shifted back to her human-form. She was sweating and her chest hurt like hell, but she was alive. As she pulled her head up and looked at the man who had so easily bested her, she was treated to her first look at those impossible, unnerving eyes.

"Holy shit!" Tori yelped, terror momentarily forgotten in the rush of confusion and excitement. "You're... you're fucking Fornax! You're supposed to be dead."

"Fornax *is* dead." He closed his lids for several seconds, and when he opened them up, his eyes were completely back to normal. "My name is Ivan, but you can feel free to call me Mr. Gerhardt, Teacher, or just plain Sir. You have good instincts; you avoided the hit even when logic told you it wouldn't hurt. Let's see if we can develop those instincts into actual skills."

"Guess that means I passed." Tori slowly pulled herself to her feet. Neither man moved to help her, nor would she have accepted if they had. "Lucky me."

"That remains to be seen. There may come times when you curse yourself for moving, for not just dying when you had the chance." Ivan treated her to his best consoling manager smile. "I look forward to working with you, Tori."

He turned and left the room, Doctor Mechanical a few steps behind. Only when they were gone did Tori allow herself to fall against the nearest wall. She didn't know how he'd managed to hit her like that, but it was hardly surprising he was capable of it. Fornax was one of the original villains; he'd been as infamous as Doctor Mechanical in his own day. The man was as notorious as he was powerful, and he was renowned for being damn near unstoppable.

All of which raised the pertinent question: how on earth had he managed to fake his own death and hide for so many years?

\* \* \*

"She's green, driven by emotions, and thinks she's a lot stronger than she really is." Ivan didn't bother stopping as they stepped out of the car and entered the guild's actual headquarters; he knew all too well how keen Wade's senses were. Or, rather, how keen the nanites in his blood made his senses.

"So you're saying she's you, back when we were starting out." Wade kept pace as they headed down the halls, already certain of the destination in Ivan's mind.

"Cute. Look, I said I'd do the job, and I will. I'll teach her to the best of my ability, but if she steps too far out of bounds..."

"The punishment for code-breakers is the same for every member of this guild," Wade said, "from its most senior members to its newest apprentices. If she can't work within our boundaries, then you'll do what is necessary."

"How is it you can say that with so much detachment, but you're the beloved billionaire and I'm still looked at as a monster?" Ivan finally arrived at the door he was looking for and nearly barreled through it.

On the other side was a medium-sized room with tables, plastic chairs, and vending machines serving up soda and microwavable fare. Ivan walked right over to the soda machine and pressed his thumb against a small touchscreen on the side. A barely visible panel in the wall slid away, revealing a set of ascending stairs, and both men began to climb.

“It’s not like people know that Wade Wyatt is Doctor Mechanical. So far as the public is concerned, he’s ancient history, and I’m the man who lets them listen to music on devices the size of their fingernail.”

“Yeah, yeah, and Fornax has been dead since the Orion incident. I still feel like I get more hate than you do, and your persona isn’t even ‘confirmed’ to be dead.” Ivan emerged at the top of the stairs in a lush room with red carpet. There was an open bar, large tables with crisp white tablecloths, and an army of robot butlers ready to prepare any drink or delicacy one could imagine.

“You’re just complaining to change the subject,” Wade said. “I know you’re worried about having an apprentice.”

“Damn right, I’m worried,” Ivan snapped. He flopped onto a cushy sofa and motioned for one of the nearest robots to come attend to him. “How are we even going to work this? I can’t stay in guild quarters. My neighbors will notice if I suddenly stop coming home, to say nothing of my kids every other weekend.” The robot made its way over to Ivan, and he promptly ordered three BLTs and a glass of sweet tea.

“Yet you seem to have no qualms about using the senior staff facilities,” Wade noted.

“Hey, asshole, you’re the one who guilted me into taking a seat on the council. Executive break rooms are one of the fringe benefits, and I’m going to use it.”

“As well you should. I constructed them with you in mind, after all. From the grand dreams of our ideal lair we used to have, back when we were squatting in abandoned warehouses.”

“Don’t you dare try to invoke ‘the good old days’ with me.” Ivan rubbed his temples with his index finger and thumb, despite the fact that there was no physical pain in his head. It had been years since he’d gone up against anything strong enough to actually hurt him. “Let’s just talk logistics: how am I going to train that woman? I guess I could come in on afternoons and some weekends, if I move things around.”

“That would make you her coach, not her teacher,” Wade told him. “You know perfectly well the way these things are done. She’s going to move into your home, be under your tutelage and care for as many hours in the day as possible.”

“Hells bells, Wade. My neighbors are going to have a field day if I suddenly have a twenty-something-year-old female staying at my place. The Jensens alone would start putting me in the prayer requests at church, and lord only knows how that gets the gossip fountain flowing. I have to live in that suburb, you know.”

The two were interrupted as the robot returned with sandwiches and sweet tea in hand. Ivan accepted the plate, greedily digging into the first BLT as Wade addressed his concern.

“I’ve already been working on a cover story. She’s your cousin’s daughter, going through a bit of trouble at home and staying with you until things are sorted out.” Wade reached into his back pocket and produced a small tablet. He set it in front of Ivan, who ignored it as he continued to eat, and gestured at the blank screen waiting to be unlocked. “In that is her cover, false history, and all pertinent information you might need. It’s all airtight; every internet search they try will show Tori’s history and bloodline to you. The movers currently setting up at your house are already chit-chatting with the neighbors and letting the pertinent details slip.”

Ivan finished chewing a bite and slowly lowered his sandwich, glaring at Wade as he did. “Setting up at my house?”

“You told me you accepted her apprenticeship; I took you at your word and assumed you understood the duties.”

“Where the hell is she supposed to sleep? I don’t have any free bedrooms.”

“The top of your garage is being retrofitted into an apartment. It won’t be fancy, but she is in her apprenticeship, after all. Frills come with accomplishments. Of course, Indigo Technologies will cover the alterations and increased bills.”



“You just think you’re so damn smart, don’t you?” Ivan drummed his fingers soundlessly on the squishy cushion of the couch. “There’s a pretty big issue you skipped over, though. What about my kids? I’ll do a lot for this council, for you, but there’s no way I’m letting some half-cocked rookie anywhere near Rick and Beth. That’s a deal breaker.”

“Tori will have tutoring here on the weekends,” Wade said. “Though her cover will be that she’s undergoing counseling at a special facility. You’ll be expected to train her when time allows, but I knew when I asked you to do this that there would have to be some exceptions.”

“Gee, you think?” Ivan gulped down a few mouthfuls of the tea and grimaced. No matter how many times he had Wade tweak their programming, the robots just couldn’t get sweet tea right. They made good sandwiches and coffee, though, so that was something. “I don’t suppose I can use her as an excuse to skip council meetings, can I?”

“Sadly, no,” Wade said. “Like all apprentices, she’ll be expected to tag along and learn at your side. Speaking of, you remember we have one next Wednesday, right?”

“Unfortunately. Remember when being a villain was all about wild nights and brawls in the street?”

“Yes. I also remember being confined in a cell under so much security I could scarcely move,” Wade reminded him.

“I didn’t say it was all perfect, but now, I swear, we do more meetings and slideshows than we do at my office job.” Ivan shook his head. “I wasn’t built for this side of the business.”

“Yet you continue doing an impeccable job. Chin up; if nothing else, I imagine your new apprentice will add some of the old excitement back into your life.”

“That’s what I was thinking, and why I didn’t want one in the first place.” Ivan leaned back in the chair, lazily holding his second BLT. “Honestly, a small part of me hopes I have to kill her. The other option is actually teaching her, which seems far more dangerous. I’m pretty fond of our world, but the last thing it needs is a disciple of Fornax.”

“Fornax has been dead for over a decade,” Wade said, crossing his slender hands in his lap. “Tori will be a disciple of Ivan. Nothing more, nothing less.”

“Let’s just hope that’s not worse.”

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## Chapter 4

Tori watched the streets crawl by, marveling at how impressively identical each of the homes were. Certainly, there were minor variations in design or decoration, but it was abundantly clear that each of the houses had been constructed from the same central design. She'd been to places like this before, usually on a quick burglary run to scrounge up money for components, and every time it overwhelmed her with an indescribable sense of horror. How could these people be so content to spin about aimlessly, like cogs in one of her earlier inventions? It boggled the mind, even one as impressive as hers.

The driver, a muscular man who had said nothing since she was led into his car that morning, turned left, bringing them into a different subdivision. It had taken a few days to get everything settled, but she was finally making the big move out to her new digs. She'd kept quiet about her dislike of the situation; the whole mess had apparently come about from how much she'd been dragging her heels in the first place. Plus, any place to stay was probably better than that pork processing plant she'd been kept in. It was nice not to be dead, and while she'd have much rather learned from Doctor Mechanial, Fornax wasn't a horrid consolation prize.

Except that he wasn't Fornax—Doctor Mechanial had been adamant about that point. It was a name she was never to speak aloud, to avoid thinking about if at all possible. Fornax had to be dead for Ivan, her teacher, to have any sort of life. Failing his training might result in death, but spilling his big secret would result in the sorts of punishments she'd rather die than endure. The way Doctor Mechanial had so coldly explained what was waiting for her if she slipped up still sent a shiver down her spine.

There a slight bump as the SUV turned off the street and pulled into the open driveway. It was adjacent to another house, one that was just like all the others. Completely indistinguishable in any way... except that one of the world's most notorious villains lived there. Tori felt her opinion of these

neighborhoods rise slightly; there was something to be said for camouflage that let one blend with the herd.

Ivan stood on the porch, waving with a careful smile. It was smart, not appearing too happy about her arrival. After all, her cover story meant she was closer to a burden than a blessing. If he'd been overjoyed, that wouldn't have fit properly. Tori's opinion of Ivan was going up too; the man clearly had practice blending in. Or, she supposed, he was just unhappy to see her and didn't mind letting it show through.

With a grunt, Tori hauled her suitcase out of the back. Everything she needed was already up in the prepared apartment, but it wouldn't do to have her arrive without baggage. Tori had the feeling this wasn't the first time Doctor Mechanical had orchestrated something like this. She doubted it was even within his first hundred.

Despite the early hour, several of Ivan's neighbors were out. Some were mowing their lawns, others trimming hedges, a few even tending to well-kept flower beds, but all of them were clearly outside for the same reason: to get a look at Ivan's new tenant. For the most fleeting of moments, Tori was tempted to greet her "uncle" with a kiss on the lips, just to cause a stir. She resisted because she realized the momentary humor wouldn't be worth the complications it would create, and because she suspected Ivan would just dodge if she tried. Years of being "dead" aside, he was a legend for a reason.

"Tori," Ivan greeted as she drew near the porch. He reached down and took the suitcase from her, then pulled her in for a one-sided hug. It was as awkward as an actual embrace between distant family members, which sold the ruse well.

"Uncle Ivan," Tori replied. "Good to see you again."

"And you. Come on inside, let's get you settled in." Ivan opened his front door and held it for her as she stepped through the entrance.

Tori's first thought was to marvel at how mundane the foyer and living room were: a few pieces of bric-a-brac, some pictures on the wall, and a reasonably-sized television sitting across from a worn sofa. Comfortable and lived-in, the house had the kind of homey aura she'd never

seen a fake dwelling accurately replicate... which meant, most likely, that it wasn't a fake at all. This was where Ivan laid his head—a head that would be at the top of the capes' hunting lists if they knew it was still on his shoulders.

Behind her, she heard the door shut as Ivan walked in and set her suitcase on the ground. Then came the sound of deadbolts being locked into place, followed by a few mumbled words that she couldn't quite make out. Magic, probably. No one, at least no one who talked to the public, entirely knew where Fornax drew his powers from, but they were obviously magical in origin. Tori turned around to see Ivan running his thumb along the seam between the door and the wall before he turned and faced her.

“Want something to drink?”

“I'd love a beer.”

Ivan nodded. “Fine, just don't let the neighbors see you drinking anything. You're supposed to be here to get clean, remember?”

“I'll keep any drinking inside the walls with the blinds shut,” Tori promised.

“Do that. And grab a seat.” Ivan walked off into the kitchen, and Tori slid into an overstuffed green chair that had probably belonged to Ivan when he first got out on his own. She was surprised he'd managed to hold on to it this long—usually “bachelor décor” was the first thing to go when a man settled down. Ivan might not be married at the moment, but he seemed too put together to have lived so long as a bachelor.

Ivan came back from the kitchen with a cold beer in a bright orange koozie and a glass of iced tea. He handed her the bottle, allowing her to see that the koozie was from the “6<sup>th</sup> Annual Green Terrace Block Grill-Out.” Tori twisted off the cap and kept her snickering to a minimum.

“I'm going to be honest with you, Tori. I've never had an apprentice before. The guild considers me to have a ‘poor temperament’ for teaching, which is probably why they let Wade pitch me as your instructor to begin with: they think I'll kill you and save them the trouble.” Ivan took a draw from his glass of tea then took a seat on the arm of the couch, directly

across from Tori. “I’m not telling you that to be mean, I’m just letting you know up front that I’ll be making up a lot of this as I go along. I promised to teach you and I will, but you might have to bear with me as I chart the course. So, all of that said, let’s start at the top priority for every guild member: tell me what you’ve learned about the code.”

“The code is the slang term for the Villain’s Code of Conduct, a document put together by the guild founders at its creation. It serves the purpose of keeping the capes from getting too aggravated by or interested in our activities, making sure that we never escalate to an all-out war with the superheroes of the world.” Tori took a celebratory sip of her beer, feeling very confident in the answer she’d given.

“Textbook accurate, and also overall worthless,” Ivan said. “The code is about survival: pure and simple. Some of it is to keep the capes off our asses, sure, but just as much is there to keep us from killing each other. For example, do you know why any villain planning to rob a building has to clear it with the guild first?”

“To be sure it’s not a high priority for any of the superheroes or government agencies. If we accidentally target one of their bases, it could bring down a lot of heat.”

“Wrong. It’s to make sure none of us, or the capes, have any friends or family in that location. If a villain acts without approval and accidentally kills some other villain’s sister, now we’ve got the start of a blood feud that’s going to leave us with lots of dead bodies and more capes up our asses than we know what to do with,” Ivan told her.

“You said you’d also want to make sure not to kill a cape’s family. How would you even know if they had any in the building? Their identities are secret.”

Ivan snorted then tried to play it off as a cough. He kept reminding himself that Tori was new; she’d been working off the public perception of how things functioned her entire life. “We know who pretty much every superhero is in their downtime. Between Wade’s tech, some well-placed spells, and cell phone cameras, it’s nearly impossible not to figure out who someone is under their mask.”

“Then shouldn’t you be targeting their friends and family? I mean, I’m not saying killing is great or anything, but isn’t that the whole point of taking hostages?”

“And see, thinking like that is exactly why the code exists: to protect villains from themselves, and from taking actions they haven’t thought all the way through.” Ivan swigged a deep gulp of his tea. “Ever hear of a villain named Orbicorb?”

“Doesn’t ring a bell,” Tori admitted.

“Wouldn’t expect it to. He was on the scene in the early days, same as Doc and me. Found out the secret identity of a small-time cape, and since there was no code or guild to stop him, Orbicorb took the guy’s family hostage. Things went south, and he wound up killing the whole lot—wife and all three children. Know what happened next?”

“I’m going to take wild swing and say the cape killed your friend?”

“First off, he was a work acquaintance, not a friend. Secondly, you’re right, but that was only the beginning. The guy went mad with grief, found Orbicorb, and tortured him for weeks before finally putting him out of his misery. Then he went after every known associate of Orbicorb’s, down to the last toady and minion, and killed them too. In the end, we had to form a team specifically to bring him down, and he took a few more of us with him before he went. The lesson here, my young apprentice, is that if you take on a person with powers and leave them with nothing to lose, you have just stuck yourself in a whole wet mess of shit. That’s why we have rules about clearing locations with the guild. That’s why we have the code.”

“Got it, code is super important. No breaky.” Tori let herself show a half-smile as she finished her beer. Ivan could be a little scary when he got serious. Even if she hadn’t known about all the power he was concealing, his demeanor alone would have had her defenses up.

“The code is the most important part of the villains’ guild; it’s the entire reason we’re able to have a guild at all. Not all of us are traditional criminals; some of us just feel like we should be allowed more freedom with our powers than the law permits. At the end of the day, we’re able to live together because we all follow the rules and keep our heads down. It’s

our constitution, our commandments, and our credo all rolled together.” Ivan set his glass down and made sure he had Tori’s eye for this next part, as it was likely the information most apt to keep her alive. “And, if you were wondering, the capes never get their hands on code-breakers. We keep our own house clean.”

“For villains, you sure do have a lot of rules,” Tori said. She’d taken his meaning just fine, but she refused to back down by saying something submissive.

“There are plenty of metas out there breaking the law and living however they choose; this frequently ends with them dead or in jail. We might have rules, but we also have longer lifespans and the ability to go outside. I’d say it’s a good trade-off.”

“I’ll admit that you guys do seem to have your act pretty well together.” Tori shook the empty bottle in her hand. “Another?”

“Nope, you’ll need your wits about you,” Ivan replied, rising from the arm of the couch. “Now that you understand the importance of the code, you’re going to be learning it inside and out. I want you as familiar with that document as one of the founders who had to fight over what went into it.”

“Oh come on, I thought weekends were going to be battle training,” Tori said, moving out of her own seat as well.

“The rest of them will be, but I’ve always thought that if I had a student, the first thing I would do is drill the code into their head until they said it in their sleep. This weekend and future weekday afternoons are going to be spent reviewing it until I’m satisfied. Then we’ll move on to more practical discussions.”

“Afternoons? Does that mean I get the days to myself?”

“Absolutely not. You get your evenings and that’s it,” Ivan told her. “We’ll talk about your weekdays tomorrow, once I finish up the details with Doctor Mechaniacal. Be assured, though, you’re going to be under constant observation.”

“I can really feel the love in this apprenticeship already,” Tori said.



“You’re not dead yet. That’s about as loving as the guild can get. Now let’s get you a copy of the code to look over.” Ivan walked over to his bookshelf, hands skimming across thick, leather-bound books that Tori had initially assumed were just decoration. As he let his hand dance along the spines, he nearly hit a small picture at the edge of one of the shelves. It was too far away to make out well, but Tori was pretty certain she saw three people and a beach within the photo. He stared at it for a long moment, and then spoke.

“There is one more thing to discuss before we start. You’ll figure this out soon enough anyway, so I might as well tell you now: I have two children that I get custody of every other weekend. You are never going to meet them, see them, or hear their voices. I understand that what we have here is not a completely voluntary arrangement, and I’m prepared to deal with the consequences of that. If you decide to try and kill me to escape from the guild, so be it.”

Ivan turned away from the bookshelf and stared at her. His normal eyes were gone, and in their place were the dark orbs with the blood-red symbols in the center. Tori found herself overcome with the urge to look away but refused to let her neck turn or her eyes waver. Ivan was trying to scare her, and while it was working, she could still show him that she was able to stand her ground.

“I want to be very clear about this, Apprentice. What we have is between you and me, no one else. If you try to harm my children, if you injure them in any way—mentally or physically—I’m going to kill you.” Ivan’s voice was as empty as the darkness behind the symbols in his eyes. “I won’t take any joy in it, I won’t feel any glory from it, but I’ll still do it. And much as I might dislike it, I am still very good at killing people. Do we understand each other?”

“Crystal clear.”

“Good.” Ivan turned back to the bookshelf and kept skimming the titles. “Go ahead and lug your suitcase up to the garage apartment and make sure everything is in order. We’ll start when you get back.”

Tori said nothing; she merely grabbed the suitcase and headed out the door, back into the world of sunshine and nosey neighbors. It was a

sharp contrast to the half-lit living room filled with threats, intrigue, and one of the most powerful villains to have walked the earth.

\* \* \*

The apartment was surprisingly nice, for having been constructed in only a few days. A bed took up most of the room, but there was also a small desk with a computer, a mini-fridge already stocked with sodas, a microwave, and a work table. The last component was the most important one to Tori, and she knew Doctor Mechaniacal had put it in for her specially. True, there were no high tech tools to play with, nor would she be allowed to make anything too dangerous while in this civilian area, but the work bench represented a space to create. It was a show of respect, scientist to scientist.

As she rested on her bed, a copy of the code lying next to her, Tori wondered when she would find time to begin a new project. Ivan had kept his word and drilled her relentlessly about the code all afternoon, quizzing her constantly with both technical details and hypothetical scenarios. It wasn't like the document was especially long or complicated. It was just important, in a way that was clearly very vital to Ivan.

Tori slid off the edge of her bed and padded over to her computer, jiggling the mouse to bring it out of sleep mode. With a few quick keystrokes, she'd brought up Fornax's Wikipedia page. There was a picture of him, blood-red mask concealing every inch of his face save for those dark eyes with the blood-red runes. He never had any sort of official costume; usually he just wore dark, sturdy clothing. Only the mask and the eyes were constants. Those and the power.

Scrolling down, she skimmed through his biography. Most of it was stuff that she already knew: his early career had started a few decades after the scientist who would become Professor Quantum accidentally introduced new elements to the world and changed the fundamental laws of the universe. Fornax came on the scene after capes were already entrenched and were thought to be unstoppable. In his first outing, he took down three of them; one was so mentally scarred by the experience that they quit the job altogether. When the press saw his eyes and the red glow that emanated from his limbs, some reporter compared his destruction to that of a black

hole and named him after one of the few that wasn't just number and letters: Fornax. Only later on would smarter minds point out that this was the name of an actual galaxy, but by that point, the name had already stuck.

The early section covered his damage and criminal patterns thoroughly; Tori noticed that most of Fornax's big crimes were assault. He seemed to love fighting, especially capes. It was hard to reconcile someone like that with the controlled man who'd spent the day lecturing her. Ivan seemed... not weak, certainly, but measured. It was hard to imagine him going on a rampage like Fornax was known to do. Up until he was beaten, anyway.

Tori scanned the entry until she came to the section detailing Fornax's defeat. Lots of capes had gone up against him, but it had taken the girl with the golden glow to actually bring him down: Lodestar. Considered by most to be the most powerful meta-human in known history, she'd met Fornax one on one and brought him down. Granted, the fight had destroyed half a rock quarry and taken three hours, but she'd done it.

The only section after Fornax's defeat was about his death. Temporarily freed from prison, he'd been recruited to help deal with Orion when the mad meta-human tried to turn the earth into an actual black hole. A coalition of capes and villains had worked together and managed to bring Orion down, but only barely. The criminals who survived were supposedly given reduced sentences, though many were also supposedly lost in the fight. Fornax had been among those listed as killed, and Doctor Mechaniacal was "suspected dead" as well.

Tori tapped her finger on the desk as she read more about the incident and scoured the list of names. If Fornax wasn't really dead, there was no guarantee that any of the others were either. But why lie about it? She had a suspicion, a hunch that made her worry she was beginning to think like a paranoid kook. Then again, she reasoned, she was already a member of a secret organization composed entirely of criminals. Perhaps a little paranoia was in order after all. Either way, she intended to get to the bottom of this little mystery. Fortunately, she didn't have to speculate. She could get the information right from the source.

After all, Ivan was supposed to be teaching her.

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## Chapter 5

“It’s called the ‘Orion Protocol’ for obvious reasons,” Ivan told her as they ate breakfast the next morning. Tori had expected him to be cagey, or try and lie his way out of it, but Ivan hadn’t even seemed surprised by her question. It made sense; he had to know the topic would be coming up sooner or later.

“Originally, there wasn’t a name for it; there really wasn’t even an ‘it’ to name,” Ivan continued. “There was just a lot of panicking people desperate for any solution they could find. Since you’re bringing this up, I trust you already know about Orion?”

Tori nodded as she spread butter on a pancake. “Former scientist who worked with dark matter, turned himself into some sort of living black hole. He’s estimated to be one of the most powerful metas who has ever lived.”

“Even that’s an understatement,” Ivan said. “Orion was terrifying in every sense of the word. Every scrap of humanity he had was burned away in his transformation. Fighting him was like going up against an act of nature. In all my years, I’ve only ever seen two other metas that *might* be on his level in terms of destructive potential. So, when he made it clear that he was seriously trying to destroy the world and then started to actually do it, a lot of influential people got very scared. Enough to where they were willing to throw anything they could at him.”

“Including former criminals.” Tori had finished the buttering and had moved on to adding more syrup than was either necessary or healthy.

“Precisely. Doc and I were crooks, and sort of jerks at the time, but we weren’t sociopaths. Neither were most of the others locked up with us. We were just young, impulsive, and too weak to resist the temptation our strength offered. We were bad, but we didn’t want to see the world destroyed. After all, we had to live here too. Orion put our crimes in perspective, and within a day of him destroying Detroit, we were getting pitched an offer we couldn’t refuse.”

Ivan paused, rising from the table to refresh his coffee, as well as get the jelly from the fridge. When he returned, he spooned a generous dollop of the purple glop onto his toast, and then continued. “Actually, that’s not true. Many of us did refuse it. Not everyone had a life sentence, and even on the inside, we knew going up against Orion was probably suicide. Those of us willing to roll the dice, however, were offered a full pardon in exchange for bringing him down. Obviously, we succeeded, and the government kept their end of the deal. Most of us were too notorious to actually be released, so our deaths were faked and we were handed enough means to restart our lives as civilians, albeit with the caveat that one step over the line would land us back in a super-max.”

“Hang on: if this was a one-time deal, then why have a name for the protocol?” Tori asked.

“Smart question,” Ivan said. “Orion was a threat to the entire world, but he wasn’t the last one. Usually, there’s a real risk of Armageddon once a decade or so. When those come, the Orion Protocol gets activated. Not every criminal gets the offer: those who revel in slaughter or death are kept rightly where they should be. But the ones who were just greedy, or dumb, or got in over their heads, they get a second chance. Die fighting or live as a civilian. Luckily, the survivors aren’t totally on their own anymore. Now when they get out, the guild is there to help them adjust to the new world and keep them on the right path.”

“These people just got out of jail and you and your goons put them right back into a life of crime? That seems terrible from a moral and logistical standpoint. How do you even keep any members?” Tori had demolished half of her pancakes already and was reaching for more syrup. Ivan noted this, also taking her lean figure into the equation. He’d have to get her checked out to see if using her fire-form burned excessive calories. If so, they’d need adequate nutritional supplies on hand for training.

“Officially, the guild is a rehabilitative facility run by former criminals to help others readjust and prevent younger ones from going down the wrong path in the first place,” Ivan told her. “We’re actually registered as a non-profit. And honestly, a lot of that is true. We do help other villains get back on their feet, and if they want out of the life, then it’s our job to help them stay clean. However, for those who can never content

themselves with trudging about like a normal person while knowing that they could soar among the skies, we offer different services. Our people work smart, work safe, and keep from getting busted. You'd be surprised how much of what we do is technically legal, assuming you have good lawyers and a loose sense of morality."

"I have to call bullshit here," Tori interrupted. "The capes would never let that happen. They're all about no compromise and keeping the world safe. If you really formed an evil league of wickedness out in the open, they would totally come busting down your doors."

"It's been tried by a few whose reach exceeded their grasp, but most of the older superheroes tolerate us out of necessity. We minimize civilian injuries, we keep our activities out of the public eye, and, most importantly, we maintain order. The capes get to be adored and loved by the entire world, sign sponsorship deals and pull kittens from trees; meanwhile, we make sure the really terrible villains never see the light of day. We're on top, and we're not nice about how we stay there." Ivan sipped his coffee calmly, as though discussing casual murder was a regular breakfast activity.

"Some do still dislike us, there's no fighting that, but those in charge recognize the mutual benefits of our situation. They've seen what a world without the guild looked like, when it was constant war between us and them. No one wins in that situation: not us, not the capes, and certainly not the regular people just trying to get through life."

"The devil you know," Tori muttered, polishing off the last of her pancakes. She chewed slowly, savoring the sweet flavor while also contemplating what Ivan was telling her. The world was supposed to be cut and dry—the capes flew around keeping the peace, putting down all who stepped out of line. Now it turned out that they not only tolerated the presence of evil but also might depend on it. The situation, like most, was more complex from within than one could guess from the outside. Complex wasn't always bad, though. In fact, if one was quick, ambitious, and a bit morally flexible, complex could be quite lucrative.

"By the way, don't go depending on using the Orion Protocol to get a free pass on whatever crimes you commit," Ivan cautioned her. "We're quite adept at snuffing out the true world-enders before they rise too high,

so such incidents are few and far between. Besides, you were fortunate enough to get recruited to the guild before being incarcerated. That means that if you do the sort of thing that would get you seriously locked up, the capes will never have a chance to find you.”

Tori nodded. She was beginning to see why Ivan held the code so dear. It was a mutual shield, keeping them safe from the superheroes, as well as keeping most of the world safe from villains who reveled in senseless destruction. Order was profitable, chaos less so. Still, she was amazed that they’d managed to get so many criminals to go along with it. Tori would have imagined that many were too stubborn or prideful to accept the wisdom of restraint.

And Tori’s instincts, as usual, were spot on, even if she didn’t yet know it.

\* \* \*

“There can be no doubt, a confluence is coming.”

The woman speaking was hunched over a crystal ball on a polished wooden conference table, her face illuminated by the soft purple glow emanating from its smooth glassy surface. She made no gestures or incantation; her focus was solely on what lay in the swirling depths of the ball. The light cast itself on the nearby wall, clashing with the robin’s egg blue paint that had been chosen for its soothing properties.

Across the room, a woman made entirely of metal and circuitry gave a slight nod. “That aligns with what our data models are suggesting. Scryanthos, can you discern any idea of when the confluence will occur?”

“Don’t press her too hard,” a young man cautioned. He sat next to Scryanthos, the woman reading the orb, and wore a white-toothed smile as he watched her plumb the ball’s depths. Though he was currently out of costume, he favored the same color scheme in his daily attire. On this occasion, he was wearing a dark suit with a red shirt and a black tie. Aside from his irises, which were stained a dark maroon, he could have easily passed for a somewhat pretentious, but otherwise normal, human being.



“I just asked her to try,” the metal woman responded. “There’s no harm in that. I’ve got half of my people trying to pin down when they think it will strike.”

“Ooooh, care to make a wager on whose department gets it right?”

“Balaam, enough. Xelas is merely trying to collect all the information she can. Since we’re dealing with a confluence, I’d trust you to appreciate how important this is for the guild at least.” This voice belonged to a woman older than any of the others looked, though she seemed at most to be in her late thirties. Her raven-black hair fell to her shoulders, where it landed atop a tasteful blouse that paired well with her slacks. Unlike Balaam and his irises, there was nothing that marked her as visibly inhuman, which was just the way she liked it.

“My apologies, Morgana.” The young man, Balaam, turned to Scryanthos and gently rested his hand on her shoulder. “If you would, my dear, I think we would all greatly appreciate any details you can offer.”

“It is... hard to discern,” she said. Her eyes were glazed over as her head tilted slightly, straining to divine the unknowable. “But the clouds gather on the horizon. I can feel the pulse of the ley lines as they brim with power. Such a state cannot be maintained. It must come soon. By the new moon’s rise, at the latest.”

Xelas’s digital eyes flickered for a nanosecond as she checked a file on her hard drive. “The next new moon is on Thursday the seventeenth. That means we’re looking at a week and a half, assuming Scryanthos is right. I’ll ask my people to reconcile the prediction with their own models to be certain.”

“Double check all you like,” Balaam told her. “Scryanthos is the top diviner among all of our mystics. If she says it will come by the new moon, then that’s what will happen.”

“I do not doubt her skill, but a deadline and a date are not the same thing,” Xelas shot back. “Narrowing it down to a single day would greatly aid us in putting people in position.”

“Double check,” Morgana instructed. She loathed Wade for making her head up this committee; Xelas was enjoyable, if strange, but Balaam could be an unapologetic ass when he felt like it, which was often. Still, no one could question that the two of them certainly produced results. Morgana remembered a time when they got almost no warning at all of confluences, and then suddenly they were hip deep in meta-humans. This was better. Aggravating, but better.

“And Xelas,” Morgana added, “send a message to the other council members. Tell them we’re having a mandatory planning meeting on Tuesday. Even if we don’t have an exact date, I want all hands on deck for this shitshow.”

\* \* \*

Once breakfast was done, Tori’s education in the code resumed. It was still tedious and mind-numbing stuff, but she took to it with a touch more enthusiasm than she had on the previous day. Now that she understood the reason behind its existence, there was a desire to become familiar with it. It didn’t make the morning any more fun; however, it did allow her to see the time as something other than a waste.

Not long after they broke for lunch, Ivan’s cell phone began playing a swelling piece of classical music that Tori recognized but couldn’t place. He scooped it up and exited the living room, leaving Tori to study on her own. What she’d assumed would be a five-minute call dragged on as Ivan’s muffled voice drifted in snippets from the kitchen. The conversation took no less than an hour, and when Ivan returned, he looked weary. The older man carefully lowered himself onto the couch then glanced over at Tori.

“You’re smart with technical stuff, right?”

“I built my own go-kart out of discarded parts before the age of five. Yeah, I’ve got a knack,” Tori replied, bristling slightly.

“So you know how to work spreadsheets and databases?”

Tori looked up at her teacher, slowly lowering the document she’d been rereading for at least the fifteenth time. “I think I’d like to know why you’re asking that before I answer the question.”

“Because,” Ivan said, letting out the word like a heavy sigh, “as of tomorrow morning at eight, you are officially my company’s newest intern and my personal assistant. Answering phones, writing e-mails, minor scheduling, data processing, things of that nature.”

“I beg your damn pardon.” Tori’s eyes narrowed, and the temperature around her rose by ten degrees. “Listen, I get that you all run on some archaic practices with the whole master and apprentice thing, and I’m on board with that. But if you think you can drag me around as your pretty little secretary just because—”

“Tori, you have a high school diploma, a few college credits, and zero recent work history,” Ivan said, cutting her off. “I don’t even want to know what kind of strings Wade had to pull in order to get you this position, but I assure you it has nothing to do with your looks or gender.” Ivan rubbed his temples carefully, idly wondering if he’d been that quick-tempered at her age. The answer was, of course, yes, but it didn’t make dealing with her now any easier. “You need to learn how to blend in with normal society, and to be frank, I don’t trust you enough to leave you on your own, so Wade arranged for you to be my assistant.”

“And what is that you do, anyway?” Tori asked. She wanted to steer the topic away from her work history, and plus, she could only imagine what sort of position the man who had once held an entire state in terror commanded.

“Project management and coordination for a software company.” Ivan gave a halfhearted shrug, as if to say that, yes, he knew how boring it sounded and he didn’t have any way to jazz the position up. “I oversee a few departments to make sure products are on schedule and error free.”

“Sounds... responsible.” Tori couldn’t think of anything else to say that wouldn’t sound derisive and only barely managed to bite back a snicker.

“It’s a safe, simple, uneventful job, which is precisely why I have it,” Ivan told her. “For one thing, I have a family to support: the pay is both fair and steady. For another, working a job like mine makes me seem like a responsible member of society. It lends credence to the charade that I’m not actually a member of a guild of villains nor a famous former criminal.”

Tori closed the book in her hand, leaning forward into the more interesting conversation. “But you said the capes already knew you were all full of it.”

“They do, but my neighbors, friends, coworkers, and children all have no idea,” Ivan said. “You’re going to want some normality in your world, whether now or in twenty years. It’s nice to talk with people about things other than how to loot a bank vault, and if you ever have a family, you won’t ever want your children to look at you with the full knowledge of all the things you’ve done. I’m helping you lay the foundation so that you’ll have a civilian identity when the time for it comes.”

“A civilian identity? I don’t even have a villain identity,” Tori pointed out.

“Sure you do. It’s all you have.” Ivan stretched out his hand and gestured to Tori, moving his arm in a circle. “All of *this* is your villain identity. The woman who dropped out of college and joined a gang, who got along by pulling smash-and-grabs to fund her scientific pursuits, who was nabbed by Doctor Mechaniacal and put into training. Tomorrow, your civilian life starts again. You become Tori, the lady who hit a rough patch but got a lucky break on an internship, and who might be able to work her way into a steady job. She’s the identity you’ll need to cultivate, to protect.”

Tori rose from the chair, walking over to the bookshelf and setting Ivan’s copy of the code amid the other tomes. She lingered for a moment, noting the various pictures of him throughout the years: Young Ivan and a pretty woman in a restaurant, Ivan fishing with several other men, Ivan and his children at a picnic. It was strange to see the man she’d read about last night, whose name was whispered like that of a legend or god, in such mundane circumstances. What was even odder was that Ivan looked so natural in them. This middle-management family man struck her as the true version of Ivan; it seemed impossible that he could actually be Fornax. Which, Tori realized, was exactly what Ivan wanted, and what he was trying to teach her how to do.

“If Tori is my civilian self, does that mean villain me needs a code name?”

“Eventually,” Ivan said. “For now, Apprentice will do just fine.”

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## Chapter 6

Tori wasn't sure how she felt about the pantsuit. Granted, the dark color paired well with her blue shirt, and the whole outfit wore quite well on her—Doctor Mechanical had clearly had it tailored—but the overall look wasn't the issue at stake. What bothered Tori was how the suit made her feel. It was like she was wearing a symbol of selling out, of giving up on her dreams of success and independence. She was going to work a shitty temp job, the very fate she'd bucked against by trying to make her own way in the world. This suit was mundaneness made physical, and it made her skin crawl when she thought about it for too long.

All that made the act of wearing it bearable was the knowledge that it was an act, a costume to protect her true identity. This was her mask; this was the facade that would keep her safe. If the strategy could work for someone like Fornax, then surely it could be effective for her. Besides, it wasn't like she had any choice in the matter.

With one last glance in her mirror, Tori stepped out of the bathroom and left her garage apartment on a course for the main house. Ivan had made it clear that tardiness was completely unacceptable. She wasn't sure that she'd keep heeling to his orders, but the relationship was a bit too fresh to push the boundaries already. Promptness wasn't an excessive demand, anyway, especially since she was supposed to be catching a ride with the boss.

Ivan was waiting when she entered the house, a crisp suit, white shirt, and crimson tie adorning his body. He handed her a bagel and a napkin before they'd even exchanged greetings. "Eat in the car. We need to get to HR in time to fill out your extra paperwork."

Tori cocked an eyebrow even as she accepted the breakfast and followed him out the front door. "I thought all of that was taken care of?"

"All the things that could be handled by others were," Ivan explained. He got into his car, checking his mirrors and buckling his seatbelt. Tori slid into the passenger seat and waited for the ride to start.

Instead, she found Ivan staring at her, an impatient, pinched expression on his face.

“What?”

“I’m waiting for you to buckle your seatbelt.”

“Seriously? You know I turn into fire reactively when something hits me, right? A car crash won’t do jack.”

Ivan drummed his fingers against the steering wheel but made no other motion to begin the drive. After a few moments of meeting his gaze, Tori reached up, grabbed the belt, and pushed it into its holder. “Happy?”

“Ecstatic.” Ivan turned the keys and pulled out of his driveway. “As I was saying, the forms that could be done were. However, due to our special circumstances, we have to go in personally to fill out extra forms with HR.”

“Is this a guild thing?” Tori asked her question through a mouth muffled by a big bite of bagel.

“This is a corporate thing. Since you and I are ostensibly family; your hiring would constitute nepotism if I were the one to orchestrate it. Even working together has the potential to be misconstrued. That’s why we’ll be signing documents allowing the company to intervene if there are complaints about the quality of your work and me not keeping you on task.”

“Almost sounds like working under you puts a target on my back,” Tori noted.

Ivan nodded. “In a way it does. You’ll have to work harder to prove yourself than someone else in your position would, go above and beyond to show that you deserve to be there.”

Tori finished off the last of her bagel, then brushed the crumbs off her pants. Ivan didn’t wince as he saw them tumble to the floor of his well-maintained car, but only barely. “So, not only do I have to work a day job, I have to do it while people are muttering shit about me behind my back. Gee, thanks again for getting me this swell position, Teacher.”

“I’m not thrilled about this either, but it was the only way to explain your residence at my home and our daily carpooling. If we’d tried to hide the connection that Doctor Mechaniacal established, it would have raised people’s suspicions. That is the very opposite of what we are attempting to do.” Ivan paused at a light and motioned for another car, merging illegally, to go ahead.

“Yeah, I’ve been wanting to talk to you about that,” Tori said. “While I appreciate how much you all have done for me, I would like to make a return trip to my place at some point. There’s some tech I’d like to recover, along with my clothes and my motorcycle.”

“Your ‘place’ has already been emptied out and your possessions cataloged,” Ivan replied, twisting the wheel to turn them down a narrow street.

“What? But how?”

“Standard protocol for new members. Everything that you’ve stolen and could be traced back to you, including your motorcycle, was either dumped or destroyed. The rest is put away safely into storage for when you earn a place of your own. Individual items can be removed by filling out request forms, though they don’t often make exceptions for trainees. You aren’t supposed to be *that* comfortable, after all.”

Tori turned and looked out the window, watching the gray office buildings roll by as they entered the eastern part of downtown. They were so bland and boring, like a corporate version of Ivan’s neighborhood. Soon, she would be one of the suit-wearing dots filtering through these places. A wave of nausea tried to rise up in her stomach again, but Tori forced it down. She had been through so much worse than this, and the opportunity in front of her wasn’t one she felt inclined to let go of. Tori Rivas could smile and nod as needed, so long as she spent the rest of her time forging the new life being offered to her.

“There’s a picture of me with both my parents. We’re at a park, and it’s in a faded gold frame. Any chance they’d let me have it?”

“Ordinarily, probably not,” Ivan said. He drove slowly through the security gate, nodding at the guard on duty while a camera scanned the



sticker in his windshield, and then pulled into his assigned parking space. “But I’ve got a little bit of clout around the guild. Do your best today, and I’ll see what I can manage.”

Tori nodded; she’d never expected a request to be fulfilled for free. That wasn’t the sort of relationship she and Ivan had. In a way, though, it was comforting. She knew the stakes with him. There was no subterfuge or trickery. It was all there, out in the open, which made dealing with him far simpler than with most criminals.

With one last glance out the window, Tori unbuckled her seatbelt and left the car. The dull brown building loomed before her as a river of peons trickled into its glassy mouth of a door. Ivan began moving forward, and she followed suit. It was her turn to be devoured by this place, and she had to do all she could to make sure it didn’t spit her back out.

\* \* \*

The Alliance of Heroic Champions didn’t have a council—or at least didn’t call what they had a council, because councils (according to their PR department) tended to conjure up negative imagery associated with shadowy ruling criminals. Instead, they referred to their oversight committee as the Champions’ Congress. Unlike in the villains’ guild, those on the Congress were not selected by the various groups as representatives. Instead, the three who sat on it were either founding members or appointees who had been chosen by exiting members and ratified by the other two. At least, that’s how the replacement system would work in theory. Since none of the original three had formally renounced their positions yet, it was still an untested method.

Fortunately for all involved, the Champions’ Congress was only needed for major changes or decisions. The lesser tasks of running the AHC were appropriated to various subcommittees, which held elections every two years. On the same day that Tori was going in for her first day of work, the head of the New Acquisitions subcommittee was walking down a well-lit hallway with a thick folder under his muscular arm. Apollo wore no sleeves; he favored a sleeveless golden breastplate that paired with his armored kilt and sandals. They shone nearly as brightly as the blond curly locks atop his head, a wonderful accentuation to his blue eyes and perfect

smile. There was a reason he had been chosen to head the New Acquisitions subcommittee for three elections in a row—the man knew how to turn on the charm when courting unsigned meta-humans.

He walked cheerfully up the hallway, enjoying the sunshine beaming through the clear windows. The AHC's base occupied a large block of drab city streets, but the sprawling compound was outfitted with artificial terrains to fit all walks of life, even those not originating from earth. For Apollo, all he needed was the sun. The shard of divinity he'd inadvertently taken from his namesake, the sun god of legend, reacted each time the light hit him. He felt suffused with power and strength, as though he were truly invincible. Apollo had been on the job long enough to know this wasn't the case, but he still enjoyed the feeling nonetheless.

As he arrived at his destination, Apollo gave three crisp knocks against the wooden door before him. It was unassuming, impossible to differentiate from any of the other offices throughout this floor, because the man inside simply refused to see his position as something that elevated him above the others. While the other two members of the Champions' Congress liked to work remotely or in private quarters when they actually came to base, Quorum viewed himself as one of the people. Well, perhaps not as *one* of them, but certainly not as being any better.

"Come in." The voice from behind the door was firm but friendly. Apollo opened the door to find Quorum typing on his computer. He wore a simple collared shirt and jeans, his usual attire when not functioning in an official capacity, and motioned for Apollo to have a seat.

"Good morning, sir," Apollo said as he carefully settled into one of the gray chairs with which Quorum and all the others had stocked their offices.

"Good morning to you, Apollo." Quorum looked at the younger superhero with a warm smile while his left hand continued typing away at the computer. Multi-tasking was just one of his many talents. "What brings you by this morning?"

"We've gotten wind of a confluence." Apollo set the folder on Quorum's desk; Quorum pulled the folder over and flipped it open with his free hand.

“All magical, astrological, and technological signs point to one striking within the next week or so,” Quorum said, quickly interpreting the data before him. “If you don’t mind, I’ll hang on to this and see if I can’t narrow down the window a bit.”

“Of course, sir. We have plenty of copies already; that one is for you.”

“Excellent. I’ll alert Lodestar and Professor Quantum about this, but I trust you are already putting procedures in place,” Quorum said. He continued to look at the folder’s pages while his hand clacked away at the keyboard. This multi-pronged focus was disconcerting to watch at first, but over time, everyone more or less got used to it.

“We’re doubling down on patrols for the next two weeks, as well as putting key people in every hospital, police station, and public area. When the new metas pop up, we’ll be there to shake their hand, tell them it’s going to be okay, and offer them an application.”

“Wonderful work as always,” Quorum said. “You’re really going all out to prove how much you want that seat.”

“It’s just me doing my duty,” Apollo said, working as hard as he could to keep his voice humble, though only marginally succeeding.

“Please keep it up. Trust me when I say your efforts are not going unnoticed.” Quorum flipped through a few more of the pages on his desk. “Also, let’s call a meeting for this afternoon. By then, I may have gotten a better idea of when the confluence will strike. The more precise a timeframe we have, the better a chance we’re given to help the people dealing with such confusing new circumstances.”

“Couldn’t have said it better myself, sir,” Apollo replied. That was true, whether he meant it to be or not; Apollo wouldn’t have been able to keep himself from adding a snide comment to the tail of the statement, however. Quorum might be after these new metas out of pure altruism, but there were many others in the AHC who had different motives.

Most important among them: getting to the new metas before that damn villains’ guild did.

\* \* \*

“This is your cubicle,” Ivan told Tori, gesturing to the small desk with gray felt walls running along the sides which separated it from the identical desks on either side. “There are many like it, but this one is yours.”

“Does that usually get a laugh?” Tori asked. She set down the stack of papers that HR had given her, idly noting that all her cube came with was a computer and a filing cabinet.

“You’d be surprised. Some people around here think of me as the office cut-up.” Ivan’s face was stoic as always, his tone as flat as a forgotten soda. “I’ll leave you here to get settled in and started on your paperwork, which HR needs to have from you by lunch. After that, we’ll have a quick meeting about what your daily schedule should be for this first week as you get your feet wet.”

Tori ogled the stack of papers before her, eyes going wide at how much reading and signature scrawling she’d have to do in order to have it complete by lunchtime. “And what are you going to be doing while I work on all this?”

“My job, obviously.” Ivan extended his arm and checked his watch, making a small clucking sound with his tongue when he saw the time. “I’m already five minutes late for a morning meeting, in fact. I’ll swing by here at eleven, sharp, to take you to drop off your paperwork and show you where the cafeteria is. Please be ready by then.”

Without another word, Ivan was heading down the dull carpet under the florescent lights toward some meeting that Tori imagined would make her brain try to eat its way out from the inside if she had to sit through it. Then she looked at the stack of papers on her desk again, and suddenly an escaping, toothy brain didn’t seem like such a terrible scenario.

“Hey there,” said a new voice from beside her. Tori leaned back to find herself looking at a young man, roughly around her age, with oversized glasses and a shock of bright red hair. “You must be the new administrative assistant. I’m Donald, part of the programming department.”

He offered his hand, which Tori accepted and shook. “Tori Rivas. It’s nice to meet you, Donald.”

“You too,” he replied. “And don’t worry too much about Mr. Gerhardt. He seems scary, but as long as you get your work done, he’s actually really nice.”

“I’ll keep that in mind,” Tori said, giving her cubicle-mate a professional smile. After a few moments of debate, she decided that since they’d gone to all the trouble of creating and telling HR her backstory, she should probably at least try to sell it a bit. “Actually, I already know Mr. Gerhardt pretty well. He’s my father’s second cousin; they’ve always been so close that he was like an uncle to me.”

Donald’s already wide eyes grew several sizes larger as he took in the news. “Oh, wow! No wonder you got such a large starter stack from HR.”

“Yeah, I got here on my own, but then was put in his department, so, you know, rules are rules.” Tori patted the stack of documents, which she could swear was growing every time she looked away, just for added emphasis.

“I wouldn’t worry about it too much,” Donald told her. “Mr. Gerhardt has a reputation for being fair. I can’t imagine anyone will accuse him of giving you special treatment unless he actually does.” Donald’s pale skin grew suddenly flushed, especially the tips of his freckled ears. “Wait, sorry, I didn’t mean to say that—”

“Don’t worry, I got what you meant,” Tori assured him. After weeks of dealing with the guild and years of being around crooks, she found it oddly endearing to see someone so worried about hurting her feelings. “And trust me, Uncle Ivan isn’t going to take it easy on me. If anything, I’m on thinner ice than anyone here.”

“In that case, maybe I should leave you alone so you can knock out all that HR paperwork.” Donald glanced at the massive stack of papers on her desk; even with his years of corporate drudgery, he couldn’t help but blanch at the sight.

“Sadly, I think you’re right.” Tori started to turn back to her desk but then paused. Much as it pained her to admit it, she’d barely understood half the lingo thrown about in the HR meeting. If all the papers demanded was a series of signatures, then she would be fine, but some of the pages seemed to have a lot of blanks, the sort she would be expected to put more than a name in. Much as she enjoyed being independently capable, Tori was not so prideful that she couldn’t see the benefit in receiving help when stuck in an unfamiliar land. Besides, if Ivan had put her in a situation where she’d be facing unfriendly forces, it was best to accrue allies as quickly as possible.

“Hey, Donald, this is my first time working for such an... organized company. If I hit anything in this stack that I need clarification on, would you mind if I asked you for help?”

“Not at all,” Donald said, a sheepish grin stretching across his face. “After all, we grunts have to look out for each other.”

Tori wasn’t sure how she felt about the “grunt” classification, but Donald’s sentiment was exactly what she’d been hoping for. With a little luck, a bit of guidance, and all of her wit, Tori felt like she might just be able to fake it through a whole day of her charade.

\* \* \*

Ivan had just made it into his office when he saw the shadow in the corner of the room. His eyes narrowed, and he readied himself for an attack. As a member in good standing of the guild, and one of the seven councilors at that, there was no official reason he would have to fear being jumped. But when one dealt with villains, it was always best to assume a power grab or unexpected grudge could lead to assassination attempts at any given time. It had happened before, though the poor bastards that had come to Ivan’s home that night had learned how little patience he had for his sleep being interrupted.

“Councilor,” the shadow said, speaking in a whisper that Ivan instantly knew would be inaudible to anyone besides him. “I come to tell you that a meeting has been called for tomorrow night. It is high priority, and all seven must be in attendance, as per the code’s agreements.”

With still-watchful eyes, Ivan gave a small nod, and the shadow vanished. Arcanicus must have sent it; he was one of only three people in the guild who *officially* knew Ivan's identity. After a couple of coup attempts, Ivan had made certain that his civilian name stayed off all records, and had Wade scramble any digital footage of him when he entered the guild hall. He wore a mask at meetings and always used his official code name when dealing with most of the others, all to make it more difficult to find out who he was. None of this would stop the truly determined, of course, but it made it more difficult. Sometimes that was enough of a deterrent in itself, especially since he represented the segment of the guild least likely to care about an attempt to grab power.

Of the seven guild sections, Ivan Gerhardt was the chosen representative of those who were non-active members. The retired villains, as most called them, or the whipped dogs, as some of his more... asshole-ish colleagues liked to say.

Ivan went to his desk and grabbed some papers for the morning meeting. Mysterious messages and foreboding warning aside, he still had work to get done. Besides, if they were calling it a high priority, but not an emergency, then things probably weren't that bad.

He hoped.

## Chapter 7

“Please tell me I’m not just going to be doing that all the time,” Tori said as they walked through the front door of Ivan’s house. “Because if so, you may as well go ahead and let the guild know that they can kill me. I’ll take a quick death over god knows how many years of sitting in that place.”

“When you become a full member, we can find a cover-job that suits your style better,” Ivan said, following her in and locking the door. As always, he ran his hand down the seam between the door and the frame, muttering words that Tori could barely make out and had zero comprehension of. “Maybe something in the technological sector? I’m sure they can find space for you at Indigo Technologies.”

“Um... Ivan,” Tori said, her voice suddenly filled with uncertainty rather than annoyance. “I think you should see this.”

Turning around slowly—it did no good to show fear to a potential adversary—Ivan’s eyes followed Tori’s gaze to the coffee table, where a large box with a bow rested in the center. It was done in a silver and black style that Ivan instantly recognized as Doctor Mechaniacal’s. Still, he approached the package slowly, motioning for Tori to stay back. Looking like something his friend had left him and *being* something his friend had left him were two entirely different things. Ivan delicately lifted the top off the box, and then let out a sigh of relief.

“It’s fine,” he said. “They just dropped off your outfit for tomorrow night.”

“Am I going to the ball?” Tori moved forward slowly, trying to get a better look at what lay inside the mysterious box.

“No, but I think this will suit you far more than some empty-headed gala ever would.” Ivan reached in and pulled out a swatch of long, dark fabric trimmed with a fiery red color along the seams and edges. “This is your apprentice’s outfit, and it’s what you’ll wear at all times when we’re



on guild business.” He handed the box to Tori, who began pulling out the various components.

“Shirt, boots, pants, cloak, mask...” Tori laid each piece on the ground as she extracted it, assembling the whole outfit on Ivan’s carpeted floor. “Sort of generic-looking.”

“It’s an apprentice’s outfit,” Ivan reiterated. “It’s meant to be generic. Full guild members get to design their own uniforms, but until you graduate to that level, you’ll be left to blend in with every other apprentice out there. We do this partly to remind you of your place, but it also helps from a training perspective. By keeping the costumes neutral, it makes it hard to tie any crimes you might commit in your apprenticeship to the identity you ultimately assume. Sort of a clean slate, in case you make any goofs during your training.”

“Wait, other apprentices?” Tori looked up at her teacher, who was examining the outfit she’d extracted. “I thought most of the newbies went through standard training. I only got given to you for being such a fuckup.”

“Every guild member undergoing training is considered an apprentice,” Ivan told her. “It’s just that very few of them get teachers. See the red trim on your shirt and cloak?” He pointed to the areas, despite the fact that they were nearly impossible to miss in the otherwise endless sea of black fabric. “That marks you as a taken apprentice. The color matches what’s on my outfit, so that anyone you deal with in the guild knows who is ultimately responsible for you.”

“Just by the color?”

Ivan shrugged. “We used to do symbols, but as fewer people took apprentices, it got to the point where just color was enough to mark who was connected to whom.”

Tori finished laying out her costume and eyed it critically. She’d have to try it on to be sure, but from a glance, it seemed to be perfectly crafted to her measurements. Since Doctor Mechaniacal had already gotten clothes for her, it was hardly surprising that the guild would have her new outfit tailored, but it was beginning to get her feeling a bit creeped out. It was something she supposed she’d have to get used to, though. Ivan had

been worried by the mysterious box in his home, but he hadn't really seemed at all surprised by its appearance. Personal limits might be something she had to learn to reevaluate if she wanted to survive in this world.

“Where am I supposed to wear this to, anyway?”

“A meeting of the guild's council.” Ivan left the living room and entered the kitchen, set on getting dinner started. It had been a long, late day at the office, and he felt that a solid meal would do them both good. “They've called an impromptu meeting, and as one of the seven councilors, I am obligated to attend. As my apprentice, you are expected to come along as well.”

“Oh joy, you're dragging me to another meeting.” Tori's mind went back to the day's activities, which had consisted almost entirely of paperwork, taking notes, and doing all she could to not fall asleep while people droned on about things she neither knew nor cared about.

Ivan turned to glare at her, an action which might have been more menacing if he wasn't holding two onions in his hands. Perhaps realizing the way his menace was undercut by the produce, he set the onions on the cutting board and grabbed a knife. “This is not merely ‘another meeting’ as you so flippantly described it. We are talking about all seven of the guild's councilors discussing high-level, important issues. Some guild members would give every item they own to attend such a gathering.”

“Cool guild members?” Tori asked. “Like, guild members with a lot going on in their lives? Or guild members who are super boring and probably don't have much to do? I've got to be honest with you: I don't buy that a meeting is the happening place to be, no matter who's there.”

Ivan glowered at her as he sliced the onions, clearly unworried by the fact that a slip of the knife would press it against his unguarded flesh. “It doesn't matter if it is ‘cool’ or not. The council is gathering, and we both have to go. Plus, it will be a good opportunity for you to meet some of the other guild members. Doctor Mechanicall told me that you never graduated beyond the isolation phase.”

“You just love throwing that back in my face, don’t you?” Tori leaned against the wall and watched as Ivan expertly diced his onions. He hadn’t even bothered to change out of his suit from work, yet he seemed neither worried about stains nor inconvenienced by wearing it. Sometimes Ivan reminded Tori of the uncanny valley: he was so close to being normal, but then he would give away his strangeness in subtle, unexpected ways. “Fine, so I didn’t get to meet anyone besides Doctor Mechanial and the occasional trainer. Should I really be trying to make friends before we’re even sure I’ll survive my training?”

“I don’t see why not. Every other apprentice lives with the same knowledge that they might die, and it doesn’t stop most of them from making friends.”

Tori choked a bit, despite her mouth being empty. “Wait, *every* apprentice has the ‘fuck up and die’ sword dangling over their head?”

“Certainly. We didn’t make up the rules just for you,” Ivan replied. He’d finished the onions and moved on to a tomato. “Any potential guild member who fails to meet expectations is terminated. The only difference between you and the others is that you already came close to meeting your end.”

“Damn. That is some pretty extreme shit right there.”

Ivan paused to look at his apprentice. He didn’t glare at her, nor was he as disinterested as she was accustomed to. For what might have been the first time, Tori thought she sensed a bit of empathy in his eyes.

“We are not the good guys. No matter how structured or careful our code may be, never forget that we are an organization of criminals and potential killers. If the guild fails to neutralize threats early on, entire cities can be wiped out, and the tentative peace we’ve managed to cultivate becomes strained. Make no mistake: we cannot afford things like leniency or mercy. Not when dealing with the sort of people who join us.”

Tori nodded, and Ivan went back to preparing dinner. Sometimes she let herself forget that not everyone would be like Doctor Mechanial and Ivan—decent men who simply didn’t seem to care much for playing by the rules. Come the next evening, she would probably meet true monsters, the

sort who were only constrained by stronger beings watching over them. Beings like Ivan.

Moving quietly out of the kitchen, Tori headed back into the living room and began picking up her outfit from the floor. If she had to step among the serpents, she'd best make sure her own snakeskin fit her properly.

\* \* \*

After dinner was eaten and Tori had confirmed that her costume fit her as well as everything else she'd been provided with so far, Ivan took her into the living room for their evening training. Tori didn't ask questions; she just headed toward the bookshelf and prepared to pull out Ivan's copy of the code.

"Not tonight," he said, stopping her before her hand closed around the book. "You did well over the weekend. I think we can move to doing a weekly code review rather than spending all of our time on it. Let's begin your practical training instead."

Tori kept a solemn face as she nodded and walked back over to the couch, but the ripple of heat around her betrayed her excitement and nerves at this next step in her education. The temperature rise didn't escape Ivan's notice; in fact, it was the very subject he wanted to discuss.

"Next to the code, control is the most important thing for any meta-human to learn." Ivan motioned for her to sit, which Tori did. "Precision, power, effectiveness, subtlety: all of this comes from control. When you can use your abilities as you wish, and only use them intentionally, then the options spread out before you in any given situation are multiplied exponentially."

"Yeah, I know," Tori said, leaning back against the couch. "That's why I practiced so much when I first got my fire powers. I can light a cigarette from across a room without scorching the hand holding it."

"That may well be, but you can't seem to stop throwing off heat whenever you get worried, or excited, or experience any other sudden flux of emotion," Ivan countered. "Besides that, I've watched all your combat

tapes from your time at the guild, and I was greatly underwhelmed by the amount of exploration you've done in developing your power's technique. All you did was throw fireballs or charge headlong into battle while in fire-form."

"I don't generally use my powers in the first place. I'm like Doctor Mechaniacal—all about the tech. I plan on building a meta-suit so advanced that it won't even matter if the wearer can turn into flames or is somehow made of glass."

"And there's nothing wrong with that aspiration," Ivan said. "However, until such time as you manage to complete that sort of suit, your abilities are all that distinguish you from a mundane human. You need to make the most of them, and you need to have them firmly in hand. Calling forth every bit of your power is how you survive as a villain; being able to turn it off completely is how you survive as a civilian. My goal is to help you reach that level of control."

It wasn't quite the "leaping skyscrapers" training Tori had been hoping for, but she was too pragmatic to deny the benefit of mastering her abilities. Truth be told, she'd tried on several occasions to find a cure for the cursed things—turning spontaneously into flames was more of a liability than asset when dealing with complex and delicate electronics. She'd eventually gotten them in hand, but Ivan was right in that she'd never really bothered exploring them. Her fire powers were just a thing she dealt with, not an asset she depended on.

"I guess I can get on board with that," Tori agreed. "Especially if I'm going to have to tag along with you to that office every day. Can't very well go warming up the entire building if one of the old guys slaps my ass."

"No, if that happens you come directly to me, and then we go to HR," Ivan told her. "Our company has a zero-tolerance policy on that sort of sexual harassment."

"I was kidding, sheesh. My point is that, yeah, if I'm throwing off heat unintentionally, then that's something I'd like to stop doing. The question is how? I already keep myself under pretty tight reins, but I don't know how to stop something that involuntary. It's like trying to learn to stop blushing when you get embarrassed."

“That is something else that you can, and will, learn how to do.” Ivan left the living room and entered the kitchen, returning moments later with what looked like a small lighter. “For controlling your power, however, we’re going to start by getting you accustomed to controlling your involuntary reactions. Today, you told me that your body automatically responds to damage by turning into fire, correct?”

“Always has in the past,” Tori confirmed.

“Excellent. Does the method matter? Cutting, smashing, slicing, etcetera?”

“Well, burning doesn’t work on me, for obvious reasons.” Tori eyes were on Ivan’s lighter, which he was fidgeting with absentmindedly as he stared at her. “Other than that, pretty much anytime I got seriously hurt, I went into fire-form.”

“That is precisely what I wanted to hear.” Ivan tossed her the lighter, which Tori snatched out of the air. “Would you mind lighting that for me?”

She turned the device around in her hands a few times, trying to figure out just what Ivan was up to. The lighter was made of silver metal and had a large plunger rather than the usual small wheel to flick. It was etched with a tasteful design, and seemed to be well-crafted from what little Tori knew about such devices. Having never been a smoker, her experience was limited to lighting candles and Bunsen burners. Tori rested her thumb against the plunger, and then, after one last glance at Ivan, pressed down on it.

“Son of a bitch!” The lighter fell to the ground as Tori’s hand turned to insubstantial flames. The shift went all the way up to her elbow, where it thankfully stopped a few feet short of the t-shirt she’d changed into after work. “That damn thing shocked me!”

“Neat, right?” Ivan asked. “I had Doc whip it up based on a toy my son brought home a few years ago. It should hurt, but not do any lasting damage. Plus, it’s fireproof and tough as hell, so you won’t accidentally break it. That lighter is now your training tool. I want it with you at all times, no matter where we are.”

“The hell for?” Tori asked. She took a deep breath and willed her hand and forearm to resume their usual form. After a few seconds of concentration they complied, and the flickering light of her fiery appendage died out.

“You need to learn to control your involuntary responses. Since we can’t shift your emotions about easily, the best path is through pain. You’re to use that lighter until you can get shocked without shifting into fire-form.”

“Oh, sure, that sounds just *super* easy.” Tori bent down and picked the lighter back up, turning it over in her hands once again. Despite being unceremoniously dropped, it didn’t bear as much as a single scratch. Ivan was right, the thing was sturdy.

“No, it will likely be one of the most difficult tasks I ask you to undertake,” Ivan said. “But that’s why I’m here to help. For example, just from observing what happened, I would say your first step is to focus on not overreacting.”

Tori glared at her teacher with a pinched expression. “I am not sorry for cursing when you tricked me with a damn shock-lighter.”

Ivan sighed—a long, weary rasp of air that pattered out from his lips—and shook his head. “Your transformation: that’s where you overreacted. The only part of you being attacked was your thumb, but you shifted all the way up to your elbow. Try and focus on subduing that aspect first. Learn what it feels like when your body acts without permission, and then try to interrupt that action before it can occur. Starting with tempering the amount is easier than trying to stop it entirely.”

“Why? I mean, I get the goal overall, but isn’t going incorporeal when someone tries to hurt me a good thing? The reaction has saved my life more than once. I don’t know that I want to try and get rid of it.”

“That is... actually a very practical concern,” Ivan admitted. He walked over and took the lighter from her, holding it in his own hands. “And honestly, you probably don’t want to get rid of the reflex, not entirely. But there is a keen difference between something being eradicated and something being controlled.” Ivan flipped the lighter open and pressed his finger against the plunger, locking eyes with Tori as he did so.

“Right now, my body wants to react by releasing a surge of power to destroy the thing attacking me. It’s my instinct, and when I first got my abilities, it’s exactly what I would have done. But instinct wouldn’t explain away the shattered metal in my hand, so discipline is required to both keep me and my secret safe. Thus, I allowed a small ward to materialize on my thumb, stopping the mild electrical current from entering my skin.”

“Really?” Tori looked down around his thumb to see if she could spot a telltale glow or the edge of a glyph.

“Indeed.” Ivan raised his thumb, and she could see a small arcane pattern of light slowly fading away. “Although, to be honest, electricity of this level can’t cause me pain... but you get the point of what I was trying to demonstrate. The first step is learning to limit your reaction to only the absolutely necessary. After that, you learn to will yourself not to react at all, in case you ever need to feign being truly human and vulnerable. Once you’ve gotten that down, you’ll have the self-awareness to stop other, less immediate reactions, like letting off heat involuntarily.”

“You can ease up on the sales pitch. I get the idea,” Tori said. She held out her hand, and Ivan returned the lighter to her. Holding it carefully, she flicked the top open once more and stared at the plunger. He finger crept closer to the button she knew would send a shock through her arm, but before her thumb could land upon it, she looked back up at Ivan. “Just out of curiosity, do you mind if I ask what exactly your power is, anyway?”

He raised a single eyebrow, showing neither scorn nor acceptance. Tori was slowly learning that this was Ivan’s “explain yourself” expression, the one he used when he wanted to hear all of someone’s case before making a decision.

“It’s... well, no one was ever totally sure what Fornax’s power was. It was obvious he used magic—he could make those glyphs in midair that he used all the time—but he never seemed to cast spells and he fought like someone with enhanced physical abilities. You just said that electricity can’t hurt you, which seems like it hints at limited invulnerability, but I’ve been here for days and I’ve yet to see you do any sort of spell or ritual that would provide that sort of protection. It’s all really confusing and interesting, so I thought I’d swing for the fences and see if you’d tell me.”



Ivan stared at her for several long moments before lowering his arched eyebrow. “First off, whatever Fornax’s powers were have no significance; he is dead, after all. Second, I said electricity of that level couldn’t hurt me, not that I was immune to it entirely. Enough power can bring me down, make no mistake of that. Lastly, I keep my abilities a secret for the same reason you should do the same: the less people know about what you can do, the more likely you are to be able to bluff them, or conceal vulnerability. That said, I will tell you where my power comes from... when I think you’re ready.”

That was actually a lot more than Tori had expected to get out of him. She knew she should be grateful for it, but she couldn’t quite resist the urge to push her luck a bit more. “Conceal vulnerability? Does that mean that even you have a secret weak spot?”

The grin that spread across Ivan’s face answered her question before he even spoke a single word. “No, I do not. That was just a general example.” He tapped the lighter in her hand, careful to avoid turning it on himself accidentally. “Now get to work. It will take a lot of effort to gain control of your reactions, and I’d like you as prepared as possible for tomorrow night.”

Tori looked back at the device in her hand and pressed her thumb to the plunger once more. If this was the only way forward, she’d best get started down the path as quickly as possible, even if she knew it was going to suck for a long time before it got better.

## Chapter 8

Tori's second day of work went better than the first, if only because it didn't require an uncomfortable meeting and a massive pile of paperwork. Instead, her morning (along with that of two other new hires) began with three hours of the "system training" that was mandatory for all new employees. The training centered on learning to navigate basic programs and utilize the company's proprietary software. She could appreciate the necessity for the instruction, and that it was given before any of them were asked to perform essential tasks. Unfortunately, Tori's intelligence and technical expertise allowed her to figure out each program within fifteen minutes, leaving her with over two hours of boredom to fill as she clacked away at the keyboard and tried not to groan when the others asked questions.

Despite what others in her life suspected, Tori's intelligence didn't come from any meta ability that she was aware of. It was simply a combination of having a knack for technology, an inquisitive mind, and the unwillingness to accept that any topic or material was beyond her range of comprehension. She knew how to figure out programs because she'd been researching software just as much as hardware since she was a child.

Tori was a prodigy, of that there was no doubt, but compared to the likes of Doctor Mechaniacal, she may as well have figured out a light switch. This limitation held back many of the would-be scientists in her generation, who were certain they would not contribute anything that the meta-geniuses of the world couldn't. Tori kept a more optimistic view of things; she understood that just because she couldn't make the breakthroughs others might didn't mean she couldn't add her own spin. After all, a genius may have invented the wheel, but someone with practicality thought of the axle.

After the system training was done, they took a break for lunch. It was catered, cold sandwiches from a nearby shop that were actually tastier than Tori expected. She made small talk with the other new hires, both of whom were older men named Stan, but the age gap made it difficult to find

common ground in such a short time. When lunch ended, Tori and the Stans were brought back into their small training room to go over company policy for the rest of the day. It was still boring, but at least it was boring by nature, rather than due to Tori mastering the material. In a sense, she knew they were all suffering, and somehow that made the burden slightly more bearable.

At last, the day came to an end. Tori made sure to thank her instructor, a pleasant woman from HR named Barbara who insisted everyone call her Barb. It was important to make a good first impression on anyone who did the hiring and firing—even Tori knew that—plus, they were going to be stuck together for the rest of the week. Best to keep things cordial whenever possible.

After saying goodbye to the Stans, who had hit it off and were discussing the possibility of a fishing trip that weekend, Tori darted down the hallway, nearly knocking over a chair in her excitement to get to Ivan's office.

"Done!" Tori announced, flinging her hands in the air as if she'd just made a touchdown. Her foot kicked the door, knocking it closed behind her.

Ivan stared at her over the top of his computer monitor, then began shutting his system down for the day. Much as he wished she'd maintain a little more decorum, even Ivan hated dealing with the mandatory training sessions. Besides, her main job was to seem normal, and being glad to get done with a work day was about as normal as anyone could get.

"Let me power down my computer, and we can go," he told her.

Tori nodded then flopped into one of the two chairs Ivan's office boasted. While some took this as a mark of opulence, the chairs were in fact a mark of responsibility. They were there so that Ivan could call people into his office and have... *chats* with them whenever they weren't "living up to their potential," as Ivan liked to phrase it. Often, these were meant to motivate his employees so that they wouldn't fall below the threshold of tolerance and lose their jobs. Occasionally, however, Ivan had to fill the other chair with an HR representative, and let them know that wherever they ultimately lived up to their potential, it wouldn't be with this company.

“What’s the game plan for tonight, anyway?” Tori asked. “Do we get picked up by a mysterious car that floats around the city? Or is there a hidden teleporter somewhere in your house that we use?”

“I’m driving us there,” Ivan said, frowning at her attempts to discuss guild matters in public. Yes, his office was warded and soundproofed in ten different ways, but she didn’t know that.

“Do we change here?” Tori looked around the room, scanning for some secret latch or hidden closet where they could don their costumes. Of course, since they’d still have to walk out to the parking lot, strutting around in those outfits would draw a lot of unnecessary attention.

“We change there,” Ivan told her. “Masks go on once we enter the garage, and then there are changing stalls for us right inside the door. From that point on, the uniforms don’t leave until we do. Exceptions can be made for fittings and potty breaks, but the masks stay on no matter what.”

“Did you just say ‘potty breaks’?”

Ivan’s ears reddened, just a bit at the tips, and he turned back to his computer. “We are still in the workplace, and proper language should be utilized at all times.”

“Uh huh.” Tori wasn’t entirely convinced, but she decided not to rib him too hard about it. They were, after all, about to walk into a building full of dangerous people. Pissing off the person she’d be looking to for guidance seemed like a risky move, even for Tori. “Why the mask emphasis, though? Do none of you know who the others are?”

“Some of us do; others have managed to hide their identities from the majority. Full members of the guild can forgo wearing a mask inside headquarters, if they should so choose. As an apprentice, however, you are expected to be in mask at all times when on official business. It’s part of your training, learning to separate your identities.”

“I’m with you; the mask marks the difference between Tori and Apprentice.”

Ivan stood from his desk, reaching and grabbing the large briefcase resting beside one of the chairs. His apprentice was quick; many of the

other initiates didn't catch the symbolism until they'd made the transition a few times. He also knew that she'd been up late into the night practicing with the lighter. Though he hadn't told her about them, the lighter had a few extra features built in. Along with the shocking apparatus, it also served as a GPS tracker, and it regularly broadcast data about its user to a server that only Ivan could access. That was how he knew that she'd shocked herself two hundred and thirty-two times after going to her apartment last night.

In spite of himself, Ivan was beginning to grow fond of his apprentice. She could be surly and snarky when the mood suited her, but she was also serious about learning once she understood the need for it. The more time he spent with her, the more he hoped he wouldn't ultimately have to kill her. The meeting would be a good testing point of that; if she could follow instructions and hold her own, there might just be hope for her yet. If, however, she made a serious error in front of the council, then Ivan would have no choice. It would fall on him to end her. That too was the responsibility of taking on an apprentice.

"You brought your costume, right?" Ivan asked.

"Stowed it in the trunk before we left this morning," Tori said.

"Good. Before we leave, you can dig out the mask. I'll let you know when to put it on." Ivan stepped forward and opened the door, ending their conversation of guild matters for the time being. He strode down the nearly empty hallway (Tori wasn't the only one happy about the end of a work day) and headed for the elevators. Behind him, Tori matched his pace, refusing to be left behind.

\* \* \*

Morgana checked over the conference room for the fifth time, making sure everything was neat and in order. Though she was a councilor and there were robots and underlings to attend to such tasks, Morgana still liked to double check their meeting spaces before the council actually gathered. It was her own little ritual to keep her nerves at bay, like Wade's Sudoku or Ivan's eating. Looking at the pushed-in seats, the tastefully arranged plates of food, and the immaculately clean room soothed her, allowed her to feel as though things were under control.

That was a lie, obviously. Things were never truly under control in their world, and even less so when these seven people were in the same room together. Some were old friends, some loved each other like family, but a few had dislikes ranging from minor annoyances to outright grudges. That made seating important, as any buffer that could be put between certain parties minimized the chance of a meeting turning into outright war. With two exceptions, every person in the room was weak to another party's abilities, so fights could theoretically be neutralized before they got out of hand. As any experienced villain knew, however, what was doable in theory and what happened in practice were often very different things.

Morgana checked the seating position around the horseshoe-shaped conference table once more, certain all was in order. Gork was closest to the door, her chair the only one raised four feet off the ground and triple-reinforced to bear her considerable frame. Next to Gork was Xelas, since they were nearly inseparable friends. Gork's calm demeanor also had a soothing influence on Xelas, and often kept the mechanical woman from instigating a quarrel with Balaam. Ivan would be on the other side of Xelas, and next to him would be Stasis. Stasis often liked to sit with Balaam, but they goaded one another on too often, so it was best to stick her near Ivan. No one was entirely certain if Ivan's power could be the one thing to hurt Stasis, and thus far, she'd kept her nose clean enough not to find out. After Stasis would be Wade, who got along with everyone, and then Balaam, who trod on many of the older generation's nerves. Last would be Morgana herself, taking the final seat in the horseshoe since Balaam would be offended by it and she trusted herself not to rise to his endless antagonism.

It wasn't perfect, but then again, neither was the council, so this would have to suffice. At least this time they had an important subject to deal with, which would ideally keep everyone focused. The general meetings were always the worst, since no one wanted to be there and often made that fact known by acting up. Dealing with a confluence, dangerous as it could be, was at least exciting: things might go wrong, lives may end up on the line, and there was always the scramble to snatch up the newest recruits before the AHC did, once things settled down.

Morgana had a feeling that at least a few members would make some of those new rookies personal apprentices, once they were officially

in the guild. Though nearly everyone would deny it, Ivan was still something of a trendsetter among the guild. Rumor had already spread that he'd taken a disciple, and many of the less-informed members were wondering why the other council members hadn't been allowed to do the same. It didn't matter that Ivan had done it as a favor to Wade, or that no one else had because the practice fell out of use for more pragmatic options. All that mattered was that some of the other seven felt that they were being compared to Ivan and coming up short, which was not something they could bear.

She felt a bit sad for Ivan's apprentice. He might be able to handle the weight of expectation and judgment on his shoulders, but Morgana feared it would break someone so new to the guild. There was nothing to be done for it, though.

Morgana took one last look around the room, helped herself to one of the catered sandwiches, and left to go put on her proper costume.

The meeting would be starting soon.

\* \* \*

Tori hadn't gotten to see the guild headquarters when she was there the first time around. She'd just been escorted by Doctor Mechanial to various training activities and testing areas in the pork plant throughout the day, and then ultimately led to her apartment-sized quarters in the evening. Occasionally, she would be brought before another individual in a full mask and costume, sometimes to talk and other times to showcase her skill, but for the most part, her tenure in standard training had been a solitary existence. At the time, she'd taken it as a precaution against her learning too much information, in case things didn't work out. It was only after Ivan explained how close to the precipice she'd actually been that Tori realized the true reason she'd been kept alone: Doctor Mechanial didn't want anyone getting attached to her, in case she didn't ultimately make the cut.

It was a sobering thought she tried not to dwell on as she and Ivan walked down the long metal hallway leading out of the dressing rooms. She'd gotten to see her own outfit when she tried it on the previous night, but it was her first opportunity to see Ivan in costume. It was a far cry from his Fornax outfit, which had mostly been half-ripped clothes and a blood-

red mask. These days, he wore a simple red-and-black costume with a mask that was all black, save for red trim around the eyes. It was so nondescript that she wondered how he managed to stand out among the other villains, then quickly realized he was trying to do exactly the opposite of that. He wanted to be unseen, unheard, and unknown as much as possible.

“Hey, wait.” Tori stopped walking, and Ivan immediately halted as well.

“Are you nervous?”

“Huh? No, I got this shit,” Tori replied quickly. The worry in his voice had caught her off guard. She was used to casually indifferent Ivan; seeing him show her concern was a curveball she didn’t want to try and hit. “I actually just wanted to ask what I call you in here. You made a big deal about not using the F-X word, and I’m assuming you don’t go by your actual name, so how do I address you while we’re inside?”

“You will address me as Teacher,” Ivan informed her, back to his usual authoritative tone. “However, should you need to know it, while in these walls, I am officially called Pseudonym.”

Tori stared at him for a long moment, and then began slowly clapping her gloved hands together. “Woooooow. You must have really strained to come up with that one. I’d tip my mask to you, but, you know, that would break the rules about always having it on.”

“Your sarcasm is not appreciated,” Ivan said.

“I bet it’s not.” Tori stopped clapping and shook her head. “Geez, did you put any effort into your name at all?”

“No, in fact, I did not,” Ivan replied. “My goal was specifically to show how little I cared about what they called me here. I am a retired member. I do not wish to strike fear into hearts or be known across the continents. All I want to do is the bare minimum required of someone of my station and be left alone.”

“Then why... why are we here?” Tori shied off at the last moment from her real question— asking Ivan why he’d taken her as an apprentice if that was how he felt. It wasn’t that she feared he’d dodge the question or



lie. In fact, she knew Ivan would be completely straight with her, which was part of why she stopped herself from asking. She wasn't sure she really wanted the answer.

"I mean, you keep saying you don't like this stuff, but they still call you in for emergency meetings and you show up," Tori continued. "Is this what retirement means? You don't do the crime, but you still have to come to all the meetings?"

"My case is special," Ivan told her. He began walking again; Tori followed, easily keeping pace with her teacher. "I was elected by the other retirees to serve on the council as their representative. That's why I'm still on a leash, even though I've officially quit the game."

"Hang on, there are elections? I knew there was a council, but I just assumed it was occupied by whoever had the most power."

Ivan gave a slight nod. "That is a big part of it; no one wants a weakling representing their interests. We still choose our leaders, though, once every six years. Every meta-human gets to vote based on their classification, in order to be sure that each group has an equal voice at the table."

"Let me take a guess at this: one of the classifications is obviously people who have retired, hence you, and I'll bet another is people who build stuff, like Doctor Mechaniacal."

"You're correct," Ivan replied. "There are also groups for those who use magic, those with innate abilities, artificially-created beings, nonhuman naturally-occurring beings, and those who achieved their meta-status by having their bodies or genetics fundamentally altered."

"Which makes seven." Tori paused for a moment, mulling the information around in her head. "What about me? I'm genetically altered, and I plan to use gadgets like Doctor Mechaniacal, so which group would I get to vote in?"

"You'll make that decision if and when you ascend to full guild membership status," Ivan told her. "Around that time, you pick your group. We're not so concerned with people having a foot in more than one pool;

the main issue was making sure that everyone, no matter how unique, has someone looking out for their interests.”

Ahead of them loomed large metal doors. Instinctively, Tori knew that beyond them was the guild, the real one, not the small selection of cells she’d seen before. This time, she felt the heat rise around her as her stomach tightened. Ivan clearly noticed but said nothing, which she was thankful for. They both knew she was working on it—pointing out her slip-ups would do no good for either of them at this point.

“I’ve said it before, and I’ll say it again: for an organization of villains, you sure do have some strange policies in place,” Tori quipped, trying to keep her mind off the prospect of what lay beyond the doors.

“And as I’ve said before, there is a reason for that. Many meta-humans become criminals because they see no other path forward. They have power, but are still suppressed by society. Eventually, they see their abilities as their only avenue toward being heard, which leads to acting out. We created a system that emphasized giving everyone a voice because it makes them less likely to try and start an uprising.” Ivan walked over to a small console and pressed his eye up to a small, glowing green spot.

“Welcome, Pseudonym.” As a voice from the console spoke, the doors before them parted. Slowly they moved until the room beyond could be seen. Inside of it were several people milling about.

Tori took a deep breath, gathered her willpower, and took her first steps forward into the guild of villains.

## Chapter 9

The large, red-carpeted lobby wasn't quite as full as Tori had expected. She counted a half-dozen people lounging about in costumes, most either working on laptops or making small talk. Tori was about to ask Ivan for an explanation when she put the pieces together on her own: this was an emergency meeting for the council. There was no reason for a lot of the other guild members to be present. The small group made her feel a bit more at ease as Ivan continued walking forward. His aim seemed to be the large staircase at the edge of the room, though he soon veered off course as they drew closer. It appeared he was going to at least do perfunctory greetings if nothing else.

"Evening," Ivan said, walking up to a man who was at least ten feet tall and apparently entirely made of muscle and his conversational partner, a small fellow with dark hair dressed in a pinstripe suit.

"Evening to you, Pseudonym," the man in the suit replied. His beady eyes wandered over to Tori, who met his gaze without wavering. "So the rumors are true; you took one under your wing. Looks like Thuggernaut owes me ten bucks."

The giant of man—Thuggernaut, it seemed—pulled a crumpled bill from a hidden pocket on his black and purple pants, and then set it down in front of the pinstriped man. "I pay this under protest. I'm pretty sure you had some sort of inside information."

"Pay it however you want, long as I get the cash." The man in the suit swept up the bill and gingerly deposited it in his own pocket. That done, he rose and stepped toward Tori, pausing to give a deep bow. "Pleasure to meet you, Apprentice. My muscular companion is Thuggernaut, giant of strength and speed, while my villainous moniker is —"

"Why don't we just have her call you Johnny," Ivan interrupted.

“I don’t know,” Johnny replied. “I mean, what if she gets me mixed up with another villain, or worse, one of the heroic lot? Seems best to give her my proper handle.”

“There is no one else whose code name starts with Johnny,” Ivan countered.

“Ah, but there could be. Especially with the confluence nigh; who knows what new names folks will choose after they’ve made it to the appropriate rank.”

Ivan shook his head, but he did it with a sense of resigned annoyance that Tori recognized as him giving up on a pointless fight. “Fine; it’s your guild name, I can’t stop you from using it.”

“Much appreciated.” Johnny turned back to Tori and gave another, though smaller bow. “As I was saying, you can feel free to call me Johnny, though my proper code name is slightly longer. It’s Johnny Three Dicks.”

Tori let out a noise somewhere between a snort and a cough then quickly tried to pass it off as a chuckle. She wasn’t so prudish that the name particularly offended her, but it did open up a whole slew of questions that Tori both dearly wanted to ask and very much hoped Johnny wouldn’t answer. Thankfully, Ivan retook control of the situation.

“I still think you chose that name just to see people’s faces when you said it. At any rate, I need to go greet the others. If you’ll excuse us...”

“Nice to meet you,” Thuggernaut said, giving Tori a wide smile and small wave, which she returned without thinking. Johnny gave her a grin too, though his was sopping with twisted humor.

After parting from Johnny and Thuggernaut, Ivan introduced Tori to a group of three people—Kilo, Meg, and Gig—who were punching away on computers. Kilo was a short man with glasses and an awkward stutter, while Meg and Gig were a pair of brunette women who looked so similar that Tori suspected they might be sisters, or at the minimum cousins. Ivan told her that they were collectively known as “the Bytes” and handled most of the hacking and sinister software services for the guild. While each

person was pleasant, they were also clearly busy, so Ivan kept the chitchat short.

The last person Ivan led her to was a young man who appeared to be in his mid-twenties, sitting in front of a television playing an 8-bit video game that Tori recognized from her childhood. Unlike most of the others, he wore no mask or costume—the only thing slightly obscuring his face were the strands of dirty blond hair that hung down to nearly his shoulders. When Ivan spoke to him, Tori noticed an unusual note of tension in his voice. On impulse, she looked around the room and noticed that everyone else seemed to be looking at them, waiting to see what would happen.

“Good evening, Kristoph,” Ivan said. “How are you doing?”

“Pretty good,” Kristoph replied. He paused his game and stood up from the small chair he’d been resting in. He was tall and broad, though not as large as Ivan. Even so, as Kristoph’s gaze fell upon Tori, she felt a shiver run down her spine. Somewhere in the depths of her mind, she remembered her grandmother saying that those feelings came when a person walked over your grave. Then, as quickly as the feeling had come, it passed, and Kristoph was holding out a hand to her.

“Nice to meet you, new apprentice. I’m Kristoph. You don’t seem like a bad person, so you can come talk to me whenever you like.”

Tori accepted the handshake, noting as she did that the balloon of tension that had filled the room was rapidly deflating. Without another word, Kristoph settled back into his chair and resumed his video game. Ivan took Tori by the arm and headed toward the stairs. She managed to wait until they were out of a regular person’s earshot before her curiosity got the best of her.

“Okay, what the hell was that about?”

To his credit, Ivan made no attempt to pretend that something very strange hadn’t just occurred. Instead, he merely lowered his voice to barely above a whisper while they ascended the carpeted stairs.

“Everyone in the guild has to meet Kristoph during their apprenticeship. It’s a time-saving device, since we don’t want to spend all

the effort of training someone only for Kristoph to kill them the first time they meet each other.”

“Wait... you thought that guy might have tried to kill me?” Tori stopped dead on the stairs. Being deemed an irresponsible asset was one thing, she could at least see the argument in that, but putting her in front of some guy who went on random murder binges was a whole other case entirely.

“Not tried, succeeded,” Ivan replied, his tone neutral and unapologetic. “Kristoph is probably amongst the most powerful meta-humans alive, villain or cape. I’ve dealt with a lot of heavy hitters, and he could give a run to even the most legendary of the lot. If he decided to kill you, then no one could have stopped him, and none of us would have tried.”

“Wha—”

“Kristoph doesn’t kill indiscriminately, Apprentice. He searches your soul for a very special type of sin, and if he finds it, then his power manifests. That’s the other reason we bring apprentices in front of Kristoph: this is a guild for villains, not monsters. We don’t want the kind of people Kristoph kills walking around this planet, and we certainly don’t want them in a place that is home to some of our own families. Many of us are parents, after all.”

“What does... shit. You’re talking about people who hurt kids, aren’t you?”

“Merely scraping a knee or delivering a spanking won’t leave the sort of stain Kristoph searches for,” Ivan replied. “But those who kill or do lasting damage to the innocent are marked in a way that no spell or ward can camouflage.”

Tori’s eyes widened and she glanced back at the young man playing video games. “Ohhhhh. Okay, I’m with you now. But why is he here, then? That sort of work seems like it puts him on the side of the capes.”

“No doubt he’d be welcome there, except that Kristoph doesn’t bother with things like due process or proof. Soul-gazing isn’t exactly the sort of thing that’s admissible in court, and even if it were, Kristoph

wouldn't bother submitting it. Even that might be overlooked... if not for the fact that the deaths Kristoph gives are not the quick, merciful sort."

"Do I want to know?"

Ivan contemplated for a moment before responding. "The tamest way I've seen him kill someone was to animate their skeleton so that it clawed its way out from the inside while the person was kept alive to feel every excruciating second. Would you like to hear more than that?"

"Not really," Tori admitted. "Although, knowing what the skeleton guy must have done, I do sort of want to buy Kristoph a beer."

"A sentiment we all echoed, which is why he lives here and has his needs provided for. But Kristoph is not our concern tonight, Apprentice. The time for the meeting is almost at hand."

"Well then, let's get to hopping," Tori replied. She and Ivan ascended the stairs, back on course for the clandestine meeting with the other members of the villainous council. Even in the midst of actually doing it, Tori was keenly aware of how ridiculous that all sounded.

\* \* \*

Apollo arrived late for the Alliance of Heroic Champions' Congress meeting, and he was fuming as he did so. In an effort to get more notoriety and become well-known, he'd made a point of recently helping some of the others with their own PR issues and debacles. That act of generosity had backfired, unfortunately, as it ultimately made him the de facto person to deal with Karl and his impossibly bad Heroic Champion persona. No matter how hard they tried to convince him to change identities, the man was steadfast in sticking to his current one, and his civil case had barred them from booting him just because no one liked his identity. Karl actually had to screw up to get thrown out, which made his boy-scout clean record a point of aggravation instead of something they could laud to the public.

The large doors slid open, revealing a massive conference room that surely must have been built to hold more people than sat on the current Champions' Congress. Sitting at the vast wooden table was Quorum, who had a pad and pen with him despite the fact that he never really needed to

take notes. Technically, there was no one else in the room, though there were two small devices resting a few feet away from Quorum. Each was generating a holographic projection of a different symbol: one featured the two entangled atoms that represented Professor Quantum, and one had the blazing astral design that was the symbol for Lodestar. The room was silent as Apollo entered, a peace broken immediately as Quorum took notice of his entry.

“You’re late.” He didn’t sound particularly perturbed by the tardiness, merely announcing it factually, as though he were saying Apollo’s golden hair was curly.

“My sincerest apologies. Whitest Knight put out some fires downtown earlier today, but then he stopped to pass out more of his ‘informational pamphlets,’ and I’m sure you can guess how the media reacted.”

“You must be kidding me.” The voice was female, strong yet youthful, and emanated from the device projecting Lodestar’s symbol. “That jackass is still registered with us?”

“The court ruled his persona to be constitutionally-protected free speech,” replied an older man’s voice, this one coming from the device with Professor Quantum’s symbol. “So long as he adheres to our rules and does his job well, we cannot expel him from our ranks.”

“Please, friends. Karl is not our concern tonight,” Quorum said. As the only member of the Congress physically present, it fell to him to keep the discussion on topic. Admittedly, this was true even back in the days when his fellow members didn’t telecommute, though that had certainly exacerbated the problem. “Apollo, please take a seat and listen closely. As someone who seeks to sit on this Congress one day, tonight’s meeting will be of the utmost relevance to you. We have many duties as upholders of law and order, but few quite as important as aiding those who suddenly find themselves thrust into a situation beyond their control or understanding.”

“Of course, sir.” Apollo slid into one of the many, many free chairs and took out a small notebook of his own. He’d been with the AHC long enough to have dealt with these situations before, but it was his first time to see the process from the top level of management.



Quorum nodded to the devices, which Apollo assumed were being fed video as well as audio. “Professor Quantum, if you would start us off.”

“Certainly. I won’t bore you all with the science I used to determine my estimates, but the long and short of it is what we’re all already keenly aware of: a confluence is coming, and it will be here quite soon.”

\* \* \*

Tori was somewhat underwhelmed by the conference room itself. Once upon a time, in her childhood, she’d been brought along with her parents to work and seen more impressive ones. Certainly the table was nice, and she rather enjoyed the decor, but overall it seemed like a room that had been built to accommodate those using it rather than impress others who might see it, which went counter to the purpose of every other conference room Tori had previously observed.

The people, on the other hand, were a whole other matter. As soon as she walked in she recognized Doctor Mechaniacal, clad in his meta-armor for the first time since she’d first met him. He still didn’t wear the helmet, though, which made sense for a meeting, when she thought about it. The copper-haired inventor gave her a small smile as she entered, which she returned as formally as she could manage.

Tori also instantly recognized the metallic woman talking with an eight-foot-tall gray creature as Xelas, who had won a landmark case for the rights of artificially intelligent beings. Every inventor knew the story of how Tech Lord, a member of AHC, had created Xelas as a sex doll, only to accidentally construct her so well that she developed free will. When she sued for her freedom, it was the first time a machine was legally seen as anything more than property, and it was why every inventor now had to be sure not to make their machines so smart they could emancipate themselves. Xelas had clearly been given a lot of equipment changes and upgrades, but she still wore the same metal face that Tori had seen in the history books. None of that explained why she was now with a villains’ guild, though Tori could make a few guesses. She’d heard Tech Lord hadn’t taken losing his toy and having his fetishes dragged out in public view very kindly.

The large person with gray skin was a stranger to Tori, as was the blonde gal wearing street clothes and chatting it up with a younger man in

red-and-black robes. He at least looked somewhat familiar, though she couldn't place where she'd seen him. Probably from a crime scene, which he'd then bargained his way out of the consequences of by killing an even worse person. As though sensing her thoughts were on him, he gave her a long glance paired with a toothy smile. Tori noted that his irises were stained a deep maroon. She had no doubt the look was meant to be intimidating, which made it less effective. Even before being paired with Ivan, Tori hadn't been one to rattle easily. Sharing a house with a living incarnation of destruction had only increased her idea of what constituted as scary.

The last person in the room, aside from Ivan and Tori, was a middle-aged woman with raven-black hair and a costume done in deep reds. She made a beeline around the table, coming right up to Ivan and giving him a big hug, followed by a peck on the right cheek.

"Must I schedule one of these every time I want to visit with you?" the woman asked. "It wouldn't kill you to come around here more often."

Ivan nodded slightly; he seemed to be just the tiniest bit uncomfortable by this strange woman's open display of affection. Tori's suspicion was quickly confirmed when he dodged the question entirely, gesturing to her and saying, "Morgana, this is my new apprentice. Perhaps you should introduce yourself."

"Apologies," she said, not seeming particularly sorry in the slightest. Still, she turned to Tori and gave a slight bow. "My name is Morgana, and I am the councilor who represents meta-humans that were innately born with their abilities. It is a pleasure to meet you, Apprentice."

"Pleasure to meet you, too." Tori wasn't entirely sure what to make of this woman, which was par for the course with nearly every other villain she'd met so far. At least Morgana seemed pleasant, and she certainly held herself with an air of earned confidence. Then again, if everyone here was on Ivan and Doctor Mechanical's level, there was no reason they shouldn't feel confident.

"Sadly, I don't think there's time to do proper introductions around the room, but I can fill you in quickly," Morgana offered. She turned, pointing to Xelas and the gray-skinned creature still deep in conversation.

“Over there are Xelas, the robotic one, and Gork, the tall one. Xelas represents artificially-created beings, be they mechanical or biological, while Gork is the representative of all naturally-occurring nonhuman and alien creatures.”

Tori was hoping Morgana would also elaborate on just what the hell Gork was, but she kept right on going, pointing to the lady in street clothes and the man with red eyes. “Over there are Stasis and Balaam, Stasis being the woman. She represents all our meta-humans who were turned via accident, experiment, prototype serum... you get the idea. From what I’ve heard about your powers, she would be your councilor.”

“I’m actually planning on using my technical knowledge to build meta-suits,” Tori said quickly. Morgana shot her a look that spoke to surprise, curiosity, and perhaps just a hint of attentive interest.

“Well then, that will put you under Doctor Mechaniacal, who you are already acquainted with, since he represents all our science and gadget users. Anyway, Balaam oversees our magic wielders, regardless of the source of their power. And since you likely know that Pseudonym is the representative of our retired members, that should catch you up to speed.” Morgana flashed Tori a dazzling smile, nothing like the dry attempt at intimidation Balaam had thrown her. Tori decided that she liked the woman; it took more strength to be welcoming and kind than scary.

“Everyone,” Doctor Mechaniacal called, clapping his hands together. “If you could all please take your seats, I think it’s time we got this meeting under way.”

The rest of the attendees made their way around the horseshoe shaped table, some snagging one of the provided sandwiches as they took a seat. Morgana leaned in and gave Tori a quick hug, pausing only to whisper in her ear.

“Try not to let them scare you too much, but don’t forget that they are scary people.”

Then she was gone, hustling across the room to sit on the end of the table. Tori found herself wishing the older woman was seated nearer to Ivan, who plopped down between Xelas and Stasis. She was the first person

to show Tori more than perfunctory kindness, and if the warning held any value at all, Tori was going to need every friend she could get.

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## Chapter 10

“As you all know, the reason we’ve called an emergency meeting is that we’ve got a confluence on the horizon, and a much wider window than we prefer working with,” Doctor Mechanical said.

Ivan had always found it impressive that Wade could deliver his speeches in a way that was affable yet still held an air of authority. Leading this group was never an easy effort; hold the reins too loosely and they’d run wild, too tightly and they would rebel. Only Wade, with his gentle expressions and powerful mind, had managed to do it consistently and well over the years. Once or twice, he’d tried to get Ivan to take on leadership roles, and each attempt had been an unmitigated disaster.

“We’ve had our mystics consulting oracles and looking for portents while the tech department analyzed data on geospatial anomalies and quantum oscillations,” Doctor Mechanical continued. “All signs point to the window for the confluence opening up on Thursday night and closing by Monday morning. That means we’ve got a little over seventy-two hours where the confluence could strike, and by current indications, it’s going to be a doozy.”

“That’s putting it mildly,” Balaam interrupted. He paused for a moment to look around the room, clearly curious to see if someone would call him out on his small act of rebellion. Those dark red eyes lingered on Ivan longer than anyone else, but when Balaam was met with silence, he continued with a slight smirk on his face.

“Two crystal balls cracked when their seers tried to look into the heart of the energies gathering, and from the fire that broke out this morning, I’d wager the AI oracle department had issues as well.”

Some of the councilors turned to Xelas, who gave a slight nod, then narrowed her metallic eyes and glared at Balaam. Though she did in fact have ocular lasers, Xelas merely chose to metaphorically drill a hole in him for the slight of pointing out an issue in her department.

“Balaam is correct,” Doctor Mechanical agreed, retaking control of his meeting. “By every measure we’ve utilized, this confluence will be the biggest we’ve seen in at least a decade. That means a lot of new metas, many of whom will have extremely potent abilities.”

“Psssst.”

Ivan closed his eyes and tried to will away the soft voice whispering in his ear. For a sliver of a moment, he thought he had succeeded, until the voice spoke again, this time louder.

“Psssst. What’s a confluence?” Tori asked.

“Does Apprentice have something she wishes to add to the meeting?” Balaam’s voice was much louder than when he’d made his own interruption, and from the gleam in his eyes, it was clear he’d been waiting for Tori to make just such an error in etiquette.

Ivan readied himself to respond but realized Tori was talking before he could get a single word out.

“I was asking what a confluence was. I’ve been in the tech world for a long time, and I’ve never even heard of one of these things.” Tori’s voice was earnest but unapologetic. It left little to object to, aside from the interruption itself, which Ivan considered a shockingly diplomatic move from her.

“Oh yes, certainly,” Balaam said. “Let’s just pause this highly important meeting so we can explain to an apprentice something that does not, and likely never will, concern her.”

“Balaam motions that we pause the meeting to explain to Apprentice what confluences are, and I second it.” Morgana, who had been looking a bit bored off in the corner by Balaam, seemed to positively glow as she stole his dickish remark and twisted it to her use.

“Wait, what?” Balaam’s clearly rehearsed evil smile fell away as the meaning of Morgana’s statement sank in.

“Motion has been announced and seconded,” Doctor Mechanical said. “All in favor?”

Ivan, Xelas, Morgana, and Doctor Mechanical raised their hands, while Balaam looked around frantically as his joke quickly turned against him.

“Doctor, come on, I was obviously being sarcastic.”

“The council of villains does not recognize sarcasm, Balaam; you were told that on your first day here. It’s the only way we manage to get anything done,” Doctor Mechanical replied. “The motion carries. We will now pause the current discussion so that Apprentice can be brought up to speed. I would like to recognize Balaam’s motion for its commitment to the continuing education of our next generation of members.”

Ivan barely suppressed a grin as Balaam crossed his arms and fumed silently. No doubt he was going to hold this against Tori, but since she was Ivan’s apprentice, there was already inevitable enmity there.

“A confluence, in the simplest of definitions, is what its name would suggest,” Doctor Mechanical said, turning his attention to Tori. Ivan could practically hear her straighten up to listen more closely. “It is the gathering of many forces simultaneously, causing unexpected reactions that can neither be predicted nor reproduced. We still don’t understand what causes confluences; however, we have learned to measure the indicators of their gathering. Now, while many of the effects of a confluence are benign, there is one that happens with great frequency that concerns us greatly: during a confluence, the number of meta-humans created increases exponentially.”

“Not only that, but those that occur during a confluence tend to be more powerful than average,” Stasis added. As the councilor representing meta-humans created by external elements, she was the largest expert in the effects of confluences. “Most people at this table were either born during a confluence, created during one, or arrived during one, in the case of Gork. It’s true of the big name capes as well: Quorum and Lodestar were both made during a potent confluence, and it’s believed that Professor Quantum was part of, if not the cause of, the very first confluence we know of.”

Behind Ivan, Tori nodded her head. There was scarcely a person alive, let alone a meta-human, who didn’t know about Professor Quantum’s famous experiment and how that had created the first known meta-humans and apparently opened the doors to the creation of others. No one was quite

certain what he'd unleashed that day; all they knew was that all of a sudden, the hard rules of science and reality had gotten much more malleable.

"As such, the time during a confluence is very important for both our organization and the Alliance of Heroic Champions," Doctor Mechaniacal said, resuming his portion of the impromptu lesson. "The more meta-humans that can be identified as they are created, the less wanton chaos we have as people try to adapt to their abilities. Not to mention that it certainly helps to get first choice of the new crop."

"So, it's basically the cape and villain version of NFL draft day, only with just two sides and you have to be really on top of scouting," Tori said. "Plus, if you fuck up, someone might level a building."

"That part is their problem," Balaam snickered, still slightly sulking in his corner.

"That part is everyone's problem," Ivan said, speaking for the first time since the meeting had begun. "When new metas do that level of damage, the capes end up making examples out of some of us to calm the public's nerves. It's in our interests to minimize those instances as much as possible."

"Make examples out of 'us,' you say? You must be confused, little puppy; only real villains live in any danger, and we're all strong enough to handle it." This time, when Balaam's eyes flashed, there was nothing faked in his vitriol. He wasn't trying to be scary at all; he genuinely hated Ivan and had no qualms about letting it show. This, funnily enough, made him far more terrifying than when he put on his cheesy attitude to seem scary.

"Balaam, none of that." Doctor Mechaniacal's voice grew a few shades harder, a difference too slight to notice in most men, but from him, it was as blatant as if he'd aimed a gun at Balaam's face. As kind a man as he could be, Doctor Mechaniacal had not been forced to fake his own death without reason. Anyone who forgot what he was capable of was a fool, and often a short-lived one.

Before Balaam could reply, Doctor Mechaniacal turned to Tori, gave her a reassuring nod, and continued with the explanation.



“Apprentice, your analogy was an apt one. Confluences are when we have the chance to gather top-tier talent before they are hauled away by the AHC or give in to their base urges and commit the sort of crimes that will get them courted by gangs or locked up. Thus, it is important that we have a strong system for locating new meta-humans, as well as dealing with them when their powers manifest. The goal for this meeting is to coordinate shifts throughout the window, trying to make sure we have the ability to mobilize as many of our people as possible once it begins.”

“I understand. Thank you for taking the time to explain.” Tori dipped her head respectfully and Doctor Mechanial let a genuine smile light up his face. Most people couldn’t tell the difference, but to Ivan, there was no mistaking a falsehood for the genuine article.

“It is our duty to pass on knowledge to those younger than ourselves. But now that you’ve been brought up to speed, please hold all questions until after the meeting, so that we can finish at a proper time.”

Doctor Mechanial turned to face the rest of the conference room, and all eyes moved to him.

Including the pair that didn’t belong to any of the invited guests.

“Pardon me, is today Tuesday the eleventh, and are you a clone of Wade Wyatt, or the original?” This voice was weathered, strained, and all too familiar to every member of the council. Only Tori found it foreign. She spun around to see who had spoken, only to let out a half-strangled gasp as her eyes fell upon the intruder.

“N-Nexus.” She instinctively gripped the arms of her chair and made to rise; Ivan put his hand on her shoulder for reassurance. He would have been more surprised if she didn’t have this reaction to Nexus. Even aside from his unique appearance, he was easily the most famous criminal of all time. Nexus rarely acted, but when he did, entire cities were wiped off the face of the earth. Despite the best efforts of every cape the AHC could throw at him, and even a few villains on occasion, no one had ever managed to kill or incarcerate Nexus. He could be stopped, occasionally, but never taken out for good.

Tori's head whipped around so quickly that her mask came loose at the corners, nearly covering her left eye. The discomfort didn't even seem to register as she stared at Ivan with an expression of naked distrust. "Is he part of this organization?"

"Not in the slightest," Ivan assured her. "But no one knows how to stop him from turning up wherever he pleases. Since sometimes he drops useful information, we've all learned to deal with it."

"Ahem; still waiting. I've gotten a little turned around and the clone thing would help a lot." Nexus stood patiently as Tori recovered and the others sat awkwardly in their chairs. His appearance was the same as it had been since he first surfaced: dull brown hair and a two-day stubble across his narrow face. He wore simple clothes and a dusty brown overcoat that nearly swallowed up his lean body. Nexus could have passed for human if not for his kaleidoscope eyes like a sea of shattered glass, always twinkling and swirling, shifting each time they met another's gaze, never the same twice. For all their remarkable appearance, he barely seemed to use them, head bobbing about as he stared at what appeared to be empty space to the rest of them.

"No, I'm not a clone," Doctor Mechanial said at last.

"Really? Is this one where you secretly are but are hiding it? No, you almost always try to kill me when I ask you about it in those. Hmmm. I could have sworn I—oh! Never mind. Another me found the one I was looking for."

Nexus gave a slow shrug, as if to say he was sorry for the interruption. As he gazed idly through the room, his broken eyes fell on Ivan and Tori. His eyebrows raised ever so slightly.

"She's finally here? I thought she was never born... must have just come along later than in the other ones. Already the apprentice, huh? Well, that's no surprise; you always end up learning from Ivan. At least, in the ones where Ivan is still alive. And you're still alive. At any rate, welcome aboard. I look forward to seeing which you choose when the time comes."

"What in the hell are you talking about?" Tori asked. Now that the initial shock had faded, she puffed herself up, determined to regain the

ground she lost earlier.

“The metal or the flame, of course,” Nexus replied, tilting his head slightly to the side. “That choice is usually inevitable, no matter how other things play out. Such a simple thing, yet it carries such consequences.”

“Look, are you going to tell us anything about this upcoming confluence, or are you just here to dick around?” Stasis was on edge—no surprise to any of her fellow councilors. They were all aware that she was the only one with cause to actually hate Nexus, and yet she was also the only one who was proven to be beyond his reach.

“Oh, you’re here, Stasis. You should have said something earlier, would have saved me the trouble of getting my bearings. As for your question, how could I tell you about the confluence? I can’t see the future. At any rate, I was looking for a different Wade. Since that’s done, I suppose I’ll go try wiping out one of the surviving Tampas and see how that alters things.”

In the span of a blink, he was gone. There was no effect or visual cue; Nexus merely stopped being in front of them and presumably started being someplace else. Tori turned to Ivan, who met her uncertain eyes with a simple nod. It was unnerving the first time anyone met Nexus, and often never stopped being so on subsequent encounters. He would explain things to her, but not here.

“I’d like to motion that we take a ten-minute break before resuming the meeting,” Stasis said. From the way she was gripping the sandwich in front of her, Ivan suspected that there would be at least two more broken pieces of equipment by the time she’d worked off her anger in the gym.

“Seconded,” Morgana chimed in, receiving a grateful look from Stasis for the support.

“All those in favor,” Doctor Mechaniacal said, calling for votes.

Despite Ivan’s hopes to make it home at a decent hour, he still raised his hand in support of the short break. They all had people who pushed their buttons; he couldn’t fault Stasis just because it was hers that happened to

show up. It just as easily could have been Lodestar who crashed through a wall, and then he'd have been the one needing a break.

Though ten minutes would not have been nearly enough.

\* \* \*

"... and if we have Baron Peppermint cover everything south of 95<sup>th</sup> Street, that should close out the schedule nicely." Quorum finished filling in the last lines of the grid he'd drawn on his paper, sketching "BP" into the final unoccupied box.

"With all due respect to the Baron, are we certain he's capable of keeping watch over such a wide swath of land?" Apollo asked. "He isn't exactly what I'd consider one of our heavier hitters."

"I'll grant you that our new Baron Peppermint hasn't quite reached the level of his mentor, but those gumdrop minions of his mean he can have eyes and ears, relatively speaking, over a massive area," Quorum pointed out. "Besides, we don't need heavy force on the ground. Most of the new metas will be scared, confused, and completely mystified by what they're suddenly able to do. Our role is to calm them down, help them come to grips with their new lives, and get them on a healthy path toward understanding."

"Our presence helps us recruit any of the truly powerful ones," Professor Quantum added from his teleconferencing device. "Once they feel a sense of debt toward us, it becomes all the more difficult to turn down our requests that they join our alliance."

"All these years and PQ is still just as heartless as always." Lodestar might have meant this to be good-natured ribbing, but the weariness in her voice made Apollo feel as though it were likely more honest than she meant it to be.

"Not heartless, merely objective," Professor Quantum rebutted. "The more we get on our side now, the fewer are likely to become serious threats later down the line."

"You seem to have forgotten many of the occasions when I had to go haul criminals out of their meta-max cells to help us bring down one of

our own,” Lodestar snapped back. “Their arch-nemeses wound up being all that kept certain cities on the map.”

“This is not about good or evil.” Quorum’s voice was a combination of the other two, both detached and passionate in a way that made Apollo’s head hurt if he thought about it too long. It was easy to understand how Quorum could be of many minds about something, but many voices was a bit harder to deal with.

“What choices a person makes are their own. Our goal is to keep them from giving in to the panic when confronted with an unexpected twist in the world they knew. Once they have control of their faculties, whether they use their new powers to help or harm is a decision only they are capable of making. But until that time, it is on us to help them through the terror that is first becoming meta. I don’t have to remind any of you what it was like when you first turned.”

Apollo actually would have loved to hear those reminders, both because he was hungry for more information on the members of the Congress and because his own turning story hadn’t been traumatic in the least. He’d just knocked over a jar at the museum, had a surreal, dream-like encounter with the real sun god, and woken up with his powers fully juiced up. For a scrawny kid with no special traits to get incredible powers and appeal suddenly... well, it was pretty much the opposite of traumatic.

“You’re right,” Lodestar said over her device, bringing Apollo back to the moment at hand. “No one should have to go through that alone. I’m sorry I can’t be there in person to help out with the patrol.”

“It will be fine,” Quorum said. “Our own Apollo has volunteered to take many of the shifts himself, easily covering any gaps we might have had in the schedule.”

“Keep it up, young man, and you may just get your wish granted yet,” Professor Quantum said.

Apollo merely nodded his head humbly, as if the duty were nothing more than an afterthought. In truth, it was nearly all he could think about, day in and day out. It was no secret that Lodestar was on her way out; she hadn’t been seen in public for over seven years, and it had been a solid four

since she came to the AHC base. Sooner or later, she'd retire officially, and when that day came, Apollo had to make certain that he was the only viable candidate to replace her.

All of his beautiful, glorious plans depended on it.

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## Chapter 11

It was well after midnight by the time Ivan and Tori finally pulled into the driveway. She'd been largely silent throughout the rest of the meeting, either cowed by the sudden appearance of Nexus or bored by the minutiae of coordinating a readied response among all of the council's departments. Ivan had been braced for a myriad of questions once they were out the door; however, her embargo on words had continued as they changed from their costumes and drove across the city.

Tori exited the car before he could say anything, not that Ivan had anything he planned to say, and made a beeline right for the house. At least she didn't slam the door as she entered; that would have certainly gotten a few of the neighbors interested.

Ivan stepped through the front door to find Tori standing only a few feet away, waiting for him. Taking the cue, Ivan quickly locked the door and conjured a few wards, adding some to keep sound in on top of those for security. So far, she'd been exceptionally controlled, especially for her, but there was no sense in taking unnecessary risks. Once they were sealed in, Ivan gave her a slight nod. It was all the permission Tori needed.

"What the *fuck* was that? I'm not crazy, right? That was Nexus, one of the world's most wanted terrorists. We're not talking about you or Doctor Mechaniacal, people who just robbed companies or started fights with capes. Nexus is... bad. I mean, really terrible. He's killed thousands of people and no one even knows why, and you all barely batted an eye when he came sauntering in through the front door."

Tori slumped onto the couch, the ever-present fight in her eyes slowly beginning to dim as she stared up at him. Ivan could see it hitting her at long last. She'd been a criminal when Wade recruited her, but it was only a means to an end. When she signed up for the guild, she'd no doubt expected to rub elbows with people like herself and Doctor Mechaniacal. She was finally beginning to understand that living in this realm, a place outside of law and society, meant that she shared it with more than just the

opportunistic and the brash. She was also in the same world as some truly evil motherfuckers.

“Nexus isn’t a friend, neither of mine nor anyone at the guild,” Ivan said. He made a point to keep his voice as even as always. It wouldn’t do either of them any favors to seem like he was coddling her in this moment. “But he’s impossible to kill or capture so far as we know, which means we have no way of stopping him when he pops in. For whatever reason, he likes us more than the capes, so he comes around every so often to drop cryptic clues and ask insane questions. Do not, for a single moment, think that any of us would call that man a friend, let alone an ally.”

“Honestly?” If Ivan had been lying, it would have been the most effortless one he ever told. Tori was in so deep, she desperately wanted to believe that the organization had some lines it refused to cross. That would at least give her something, a sense of morality to hang on to.

“It’s the absolute truth,” he told her, because it was. “But make no mistake: we do have members whose death tolls, while smaller than Nexus’s, are still considerable. Nexus could be a member of our guild, were he willing to follow the code and pay the appropriate dues. It is not morality that bars him, only his own impulsive actions.”

Tori’s face, which had begun to fill with life as Ivan told her that Nexus was not a friend, deflated. It was as if he had drained the very hope from her smile, which he was keenly aware that he had, in a way.

“I’ve told you this before, Apprentice: we are not good people. Our guild is not the place where those of strong morality and goodness come to lay their heads. We are villains, rogues, and scoundrels. The people we bring into our fold are of that ilk as well. That is the organization that found you, that is what you seek to join. Never, under any circumstances, should you delude yourself about what we, and you, are.”

“Jesus, Ivan. I... I didn’t want something like this. I know I don’t have the cleanest record— maybe I’m too quick with a punch or casual about theft—but... I’m not that *bad*. I don’t know if I can do this. Even if death is waiting for me on the chance that I fail, I don’t know if I can live the rest of my life surrounded by that sort of people.” Tori turned her head to the ground and slowly rubbed her left hand with her right one. In the



short time they'd been together, Ivan realized it was the first time he'd seen her completely let her guard down. It was good to know that she could, when the occasion demanded it. Some people got too stuck behind their walls and were unable to break free, even when they desperately wanted to.

"If you thought you could handle it, I'd be worried." Ivan walked across the living room, heading for the bookshelf. "Tori, what did I tell you was the most important thing that I could teach you as my apprentice?"

"The code," she replied automatically. He'd drilled it into her endlessly since her arrival, in no small part as preparation for precisely this moment.

"That's right: the code, the law that all members of the guild follow. People who have no care for the laws of religion, man, or society are still bound by the ones we have set down. For the vast majority of our members, it is the only set of rules they respect, let alone obey." Ivan took his worn, leather-bound copy of the code off the shelf and walked back over to Tori. "All members of the guild, regardless of who they were before recruitment, are bound to the code. Or else."

He held it out to her, the book steady in the care of Ivan's powerful grip. Slowly, with the soft light of comprehension beginning to glow in her eyes, Tori reached out and took it from him.

"The first of us who were set free weren't the worst of the lot, though we were some of the most powerful. More than anything, I think we valued freedom and adventure over society's regulations. Perhaps, in another time, we'd have been cowboys, or pirates, or settlers. Sadly, when you pair the kind of power we had with that spirit and youth, you often end up with criminals. But after being chained down, we saw that our kind needed *some* rules, even if they were only bare-bones, so that we could have that freedom we craved so dearly. In the course of it, we also realized that some metas would never be cowed by the threats of those chained by law. They would only respond to the thing they respected: power. In that way, the guild was founded to guide those of us who sought freedom and to contain those of us who sought destruction."

Tori held the book in her hand and stared at Ivan with an expression he'd yet to encounter on her face. He'd seen mere glimpses of it when she

glanced at Wade, but never had such sentiment been turned in his direction. It wouldn't be until later that night when sleep evaded him—as it often did after a Nexus visit—that Ivan would begin to suspect the truth behind her expression.

It was admiration.

“The code is the most important thing I can teach. It's the most important thing you can learn. It's the most important thing the guild has ever produced, and upholding it is the most important job you will ever have, should you become a member.”

“Sort of seems like you're doing the capes' work for them,” Tori noted. She held the book tightly, and as she did, the weight that had dragged her down seemed to lift, if only a pound at a time.

“Keeping wanton destruction in check is everyone's work,” Ivan replied. “I don't want some sociopath wiping out my home, or my friends, or my family, any more than a human would. Besides, the capes aren't allowed to dish out the sort of penalties we can. Our jobs are entirely different.”

“I'm beginning to see that,” Tori said. She pulled herself off the couch in a single fluid move, tucking the book under her arm as she did so. “I'm going to hit the hay. We've got work in the morning, after all.”

“Spoken like a true mundane assistant. I'm verging on proud,” Ivan smiled at her, not because he felt particularly cheerful, but because he knew she needed it. Tough as Tori was, facing some truths required a bit of support.

“But tomorrow evening, I want to learn more about the guild,” she continued. “And about Nexus, since he said a lot of weird stuff you didn't seem fazed by at all. I'm guessing you've got more information on him than the masses.”

“Why would you want to know more about that man?”

“Because he's not one of us, which means he could easily be an enemy one day. I'm a thinker, remember? I like to go into these situations with as much information as possible.”

Ivan said nothing but gave her a polite nod. It was a good answer, and that made it a good reason. She wasn't wrong, either. No one knew when, but it was always possible that Nexus could make himself an enemy. When that day came, they were all better served with a few countermeasures, or at least plans, in place.

"Oh, one question before I head out, though. I'll probably forget if I wait," Tori said, turning around from her trek to the garage apartment. "That Balaam guy clearly hates your guts, and I'm sure there's a story there, but why did he keep referring to you as a dog? He called you 'little puppy' like three times, and when your water went down the wrong pipe, he suggested you had kennel cough. The hell is that about?"

Ivan suppressed a sigh; he'd expected her to be astute enough to pick up on that. Of course, that didn't always mean he was happy to be right. "Balaam, along with some other members of the guild, like to refer to the retired members as 'beaten dogs.' They feel that the only way for a villain to retire is in the permanent, graveyard fashion. Anything less is seen as weakness, as though we had the fight kicked out of us and have gone home to lick our wounds."

"Great, so on top of unstoppable monsters and heartless killers, you also have run-of-the-mill douchebags." Tori shook her head, sending her dark hair tumbling about. "Tell me that, if it came down to it, you could at least beat that guy."

"Councilors are forbidden from actually doing battle with one another in all but the most extreme of circumstances," Ivan told her.

"I sort of figured that when no one threw a punch tonight, but I'm not talking about next week. Just, you know, some magical hypothetical time and place occurs and you two could scrap it out. Would you win?"

"In that very unlikely situation, assuming I could safely engage him without betraying the code I helped write or the guild I helped create..."

Ivan paused. Tori twirled her finger in the air, the universal sign to get on with it. Generally, as a rule, he avoided bragging, but as Ivan contemplated his answer, he realized that he had no qualms with merely telling his apprentice a truthful answer to her question.

“In that case... I would whip the shit out of him.”

Tori raised her eyebrows and let out a low whistle. “Now that’s what a girl wants to hear from her teacher.”

\* \* \*

Unlike Ivan and Tori, Balaam hadn’t gone right home after the meeting was over. Instead, he’d headed down to his department and begun doling out assignments for the upcoming confluence. Magic users were, by and large, a nocturnal bunch, so his task was far easier to accomplish while the sun was down. Of course, if he were asked about it by any of the other councilors, Balaam would have claimed he did it because he didn’t need rest when top-priority events like these were at hand.

Once all the mystical messages, teleported whispers, and e-mails had been sent out, Balaam retired to his quarters inside the guild’s offices. They were spacious, and he’d spent a fair bit of effort customizing them once he earned the penthouse-level accommodations that came with a seat on the council. Blood-red walls decorated with tasteful pieces of art that were either stolen or expert reproductions ran throughout the space. In truth, Balaam would have preferred something a little more color-neutral, but certain sacrifices were necessary when one had an image to keep up. His furniture, at least, had a more modern flair that suited his sensibilities. Décor was one thing, but he refused to compromise on comfort. Since decadence was sort of evil-ish, he felt like this suited his persona well enough to get away with it. And if it didn’t, then so be it. One of the perks of the position he’d worked so hard to attain was that he was allowed to break rank on occasion. He was the one people had to impress, not vice versa.

A quick shower purged away the day, and Balaam was debating between reading his weathered, ancient tome of a spellbook or watching reality television when a sharp needle of pain flashed behind his right eye. Most men would have been alarmed by the sudden discomfort, but Balaam merely grumbled to himself as he went to his work desk and pulled a silver mirror from a carefully-padded black box in the bottom drawer.

Unlike the majority of the bobbles and trinkets he’d either inherited, acquired, or stolen, this mirror was a true artifact. Most magical items had

merely been given some modicum of enchantment by a competent mage, but the mirror resting before him had an actual magic core inside that powered it, as did its twin. The set comprised one of the most valuable pieces ever to have entered Balaam's collection, and he'd gotten excellent use out of the twin mirrors since almost the moment he acquired them.

The pain throbbed again, and Balaam bit back a curse. He could have set any manner of notification spell for when the mirror's twin called out, but he'd chosen pain for many reasons—the most important of which was that it was something only he could perceive. Sounds were overheard, glowing runes noticed, but pain belonged only to its owner. The moment he rested his hands on the mirror's cool, slick surface, the ache faded into nothing more than a memory.

*“Took you long enough.”* The voice filled his head and caused his fingers to tingle, but otherwise was nothing more than a phantom.

“No need to be snippy, I've had quite the busy day.” Though Balaam could hear these words as he spoke them, no sound actually left his mouth. Instead, it carried through his body, into the mirror, and filled the mind of the recipient just as their voice came to him.

*“As have I. The confluence draws near, and it seems that this will be the biggest we've borne witness to.”*

“There's no question about that. We're going to see a lot of new metas, though only time will tell whether or not they are actually top-tier.”

*“Quality or quantity, so long as we get enough, I think we'll finally have what we need to make our move.”*

“I like the enthusiasm, but I'm going to see what we actually reel in before I start planning the fish-fry.” As soon as the words were out of his mouth, Balaam wished he could reclaim them. That was an idiom of the river-dwelling child he'd been, not the mystical master of the occult he was.

*“Accurate, if a bit oddly stated. We'll see what sort of crop the confluence reaps, then make our plans from there. But I must tell you, I'm growing impatient at all this waiting.”*

“You and I both,” Balaam agreed, thankful that his partner had let the phrase pass largely unremarked on and a bit jealous of the much-cooler reaping analogy. “Living in the shadows, hiding our glory at every turn... this guild is scarcely any better than Pseudonym and his ilk. Our tails have been tucked between our legs for far too long. It is time we reclaimed the pride that is rightfully ours.”

*“Couldn’t agree with you more. Soon we can move, but first, we’ll see what gifts the confluence delivers.”*

“Then let’s cross our fingers,” Balaam replied. “And hope that the next few days prove to be very, very interesting.”

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## Chapter 12

Much as Tori loathed to admit it, she was getting the hang of being an office drone. The work wasn't challenging: not for most employees and not for someone who'd been able to build functioning robotic cars before she'd tested out of the third grade. The hard part was bearing through the pointlessness of it all. So much of Ivan's work, and therefore her work, fell into the category of metrics. Forms, files, and hours of people's days were dedicated to tracking what they, and those in their departments, were doing.

Wednesday morning, during a period where she had nothing to do but tried to look busy, Tori did some rough number-crunching and estimated that no fewer than two hundred billable hours were being pissed away every week on such tasks. When she brought it up to Ivan, he simply nodded, then told her she'd lowballed some of the values she used for her calculations.

Realizing that much of her day job was pointless had been a bitter pill, though Tori was able to take great comfort in the knowledge that for her, thankfully, it was nothing more than the bland coating disguising her exciting true life. She wasn't sure how the others in the office managed to cope with such a harsh reality, though the bloodshot eyes and obvious hangovers sported by many gave her a solid guess.

Donald seemed to find relief in video games, which had taken Tori all of half a day to figure out. Aside from the figurines he kept on his desk, Donald also liked to wax on at length about *Legacy World*, the MMO he spent great swaths of his free time playing. Adding in that he kept a handheld device to play during his lunch hour, which was actually a carefully-timed thirty-five minutes, and Donald couldn't have been more obvious in his geekery unless he showed up to work dressed like his game avatar.

Strangely, Tori found she enjoyed working next to Donald in spite of his passion for games, or perhaps even because of it. Dealing with Ivan and the others in the guild could be tiring, and for the last several years, she'd been around no one but ruthless criminals and petty inventors, sometimes

even people who fell into both categories. It was nice dealing with someone as straightforward as Donald. There was no hidden agenda or unseemly secrets; the man simply loved his games and was happy to share that with anyone who would talk to him.

Plus, it was nice chatting with someone who wasn't entirely technologically incompetent. Donald certainly wouldn't be able to keep up with her or Doctor Mechaniacal, but as he described his new computer setup over their Thursday morning coffee, Tori found herself somewhat impressed by the amount of technical acumen he'd put into creating it.

"Anyway, the last piece comes in tonight, and that's the power supply. By the time I log in for my guild's raid, I'm going to be sporting a system that no one short of a tech company can rival," Donald boasted.

He took a sip from his coffee mug, and then quickly pulled it away from his mouth. Tori was keeping count, and in the time she'd been at the company, Donald had burned his tongue on his morning coffee no fewer than eight times. She drank from her own, unbothered by the degree of heat a mere recently-boiled liquid could impart. Even if it had been scalding, Tori would have barely noticed. She didn't consider her powers to come with many perks, but being essentially fireproof was useful, especially for someone who tinkered about in a lab so much.

"Why do you need that much processing power? Any mid-range desktop can run *Legacy World*, no problem. Hell, they ported it to the new Indigo Gamesystem. If a console can handle it, your computer sure could." Tori hadn't actually played the game herself, but she'd done some light research in the interest of keeping conversations flowing with her cubemate. Tori had also looked up local gastro pubs, dog shows, and rare kinds of tea in order to fit in well with those she met in the office. Ivan had heartily approved.

Donald stared at her as though she'd just suggested he scrap all of his gear and start over as a level one character. "It's not about just being able to run it; it's about being the best. Every advantage you can get, every drop you manage to snag that bumps your stats, every bit of lag they have and you don't, all of it is essential to becoming the strongest player on the server. There are people out there with higher levels and better gear than



me, so while I level up the software part slowly, I'm also doing my best to keep ahead on hardware."

In a strange way, Tori got what he meant. Being an inventor out on one's own meant struggling against people with entire corporations working for them. The odds were stacked infinitely in their favor, so she'd had to grab on to every advantage she could. Donald had his over-clocked computer; she had a guild of semi-murderous villains.

"Wait, how are you not at max level yet? That game has been out for two years," Tori said.

Donald blew on his coffee and took a tentative sip. This time, it didn't cause him to wince in pain, so the burn count stayed at eight. "There was an expansion released this week. People who don't have jobs got to play for days on end, but I'm stuck coming here, so I can only play for like twelve hours a day."

Tori did some quick math and realized that after eight hours at the office, plus some time for driving, that meant Donald was only sleeping two to three hours a night. She marveled that he hadn't slammed a coffee drip straight into his veins.

"But it's not all bad," Donald continued. "The raised levels and new dungeons came with a whole slew of new gear. My guild was so far behind the others in terms of top-tier equipment that we'd have never caught up. All the old stuff is pretty much useless now; it's an even playing field as we all try and get the new top-of-the-line stuff."

"You sound weirdly happy for someone who just had all of their previous hard work invalidated by a single expansion," Tori pointed out.

"I guess I could see it that way, but I prefer to think of it as a new challenge. Besides, if I want a game I could just win and be done with, I'd play through one of the *Blaster Brahs* sequels again. MMOs are fun mostly *because* they always keep going." Donald glanced down at the small digital watch on his wrist. Tori had thought it was a joke or ironic statement when she first caught sight of the black plastic band, but it seemed Donald actually saw use in wearing a timepiece despite his cell phone being perfectly able to tell him the current time.

“Darn, we need to head back to our desk,” Donald said. “Break ends in three minutes.”

Tori sighed, but picked up her mug and rose from the small plastic table they’d been sitting at in the break room. If she and Donald weren’t checked back in at their computers by the time those three minutes were up, the scheduling software would peg them as being out of compliance with their timetables. Her fingers itched as she thought about how easy it would be to modify the programming so that she was no longer chained to a schedule, but she resisted. In a workplace full of computer people, someone had surely beaten her to the punch and no doubt the company had safeguards in place. Much as Tori believed she could get through them, that wouldn’t really be in the spirit of blending in. Instead, she took her coffee back to her desk and logged in like the good little intern she was.

“So, obviously, I’m spending my weekend testing the system and maxing out my level,” Donald said, plopping down in his chair next to her. “What are you going to do with yours?”

“Might go check out the town,” Tori said. In truth, she was either going to be by Ivan’s side dealing with the confluence or at a guild location beginning her next round of combat training. It all depended on how things went down. On the upside, at least either option seemed more exciting than another day of office drudgery.

\* \* \*

“This is really short notice.”

The woman on the other end of the line was terse, which was to be expected, but it still made Ivan want to dig his hands into the side of his desk. He resisted, partially because such displays of power would raise far too many unnecessary eyebrows and partially because he was quite fond of his desk. He’d worked hard to rise high enough in the company to warrant a nice one.

“I recognize that, and I’ve already apologized. Believe me, the last thing I want to do is go without seeing them, but I’m afraid there’s no way for me to get out of this work event. I’m just asking to switch weekends. Please.”

Janet huffed on the other end of the phone, a sound he knew all too well was accompanied by a roll of the eyes and a soft toss of her dark hair. He felt for his ex-wife, truly he did. They had never been meant to be tied together in any lasting capacity. She'd been going through a bad boy phase; he was about as bad as they came. Once Rick was born and Ivan was freed from prison, they tried to make an honest go of it, which was how Beth came along. Even so, it became clear within a few years that they were only making each other miserable. Now she was connected to a man she had nothing in common with save for children they both loved and was burdened with keeping his secret from those same offspring. It wasn't a fun position for anyone, let alone when the ex-husband in question was an internationally-known criminal.

"Fine," she said at last. "Juan has been wanting to check out the museum's new post-meta art exhibit, and it closes this weekend anyway. He'll be glad we can bring the kids along. Just don't make a habit out of this, okay?"

Ivan winced inwardly. That had, sadly, been the easy part of the conversation. Next came the real hurdle. "Actually... why don't you and the kids—and Juan, of course—take a mini-vacation? There's an amusement park that just opened outside New Denver. I went ahead and grabbed VIP passes for everyone. Go and have a fun time; think of it as my apology for the inconvenience."

"Ivan, what are... oh hell." Static and shuffling filled the phone as Janet relocated to somewhere he assumed was more private. When she spoke again, her voice was a hushed whisper. "Ivan, are you ditching your children for a... *thing*?"

"I am not *ditching* them, we're trading weekends," Ivan snapped. He knew better than to take her bait, but the insinuation that he was trying to be rid of his kids irked him. After a few deep breaths to calm down, he tried again. "Listen, Janet, I'm not sure what you think a 'thing' is, and I don't feel like over the phone is a great place to talk about it. This is just an act of goodwill from me. Even if you don't accept, I think it's good for the kids to get away once in a while. See new towns, get some real life experience. Really, taking them anywhere outside Ridge City would probably be good for them this weekend."

Janet's silence stretched for several moments, and Ivan feared she was trying to build enough steam to protest his suggestion. Thankfully, when she finally spoke again, it was with a tone of acceptance, albeit a still hushed and whispered acceptance.

"Maybe that's a good idea. Perhaps we should even take a long weekend, if needed."

Ivan had little love in his heart for his ex-wife, but he was constantly thankful that she was smart and pragmatic. She might not know much about what he did with the guild these days, but Janet still trusted that when he said to get the kids out of town, it was for a good reason.

"I'd leave this afternoon, if you can. No one learns on a Friday, after all. As for coming back, they'll probably have all the experience they need by Sunday evening. Just pay attention, I'm certain you'll know if they need longer."

"We'll be sure to do that," Janet said, her tone back at a normal conversational level.

Ivan hung up and let out a soft sigh of relief. He would have done whatever it took to get them out of town during a confluence. Meta-humans would be all over, many with powers they had no idea how to control. Even with the capes about trying to keep the peace, there would be some casualties. There always were. Between the needs of the guild and dealing with Tori, Ivan couldn't secretly watch over his family like he had so many times before. Better to get them clear than see them hurt, or worse... turned into metas. The last thing Ivan wanted was for his children to get powers, an eventuality that would make them viable targets for the many enemies he'd racked up over the years. As humans they were safe, and Ivan aimed to keep them that way.

That tended to, he checked his schedule, a paper one that he had the perk of managing himself rather than having his time tracked by a computer. It was a light day in terms of meetings, which was actually unfortunate. Now that his family was safe, Ivan didn't want to dwell on the other issue that lay heavily on his mind: namely, the risks of having an untested apprentice during a confluence.

The tall man rose from his desk and picked up an empty coffee mug. If the schedule refused to keep him busy, he'd just have to go check in on his employees. They were bound to have enough problems and excuses to at least help him stay mildly entertained.

\* \* \*

“Wade, do you have a moment?”

Morgana stood outside Wade Wyatt's metal and glass office, waiting patiently until he glanced up from the laptop he'd been diligently clacking away on. Officially, she worked for Indigo Technologies as a freelance associate consultant. This meant no one knew what exactly she did, but they also didn't think anything of her stopping in to chat with the boss at odd hours. It was a job Wade offered to any of the guild's councilors that he trusted, though only Morgana and Xelas had taken him up on it.

“Of course, Lynn. You know I always have time for you.” Wade felt a touch strange using her mundane name in any setting. This wasn't the case with all guild members, but he felt that Morgana's moniker fit the woman he'd spent years working alongside far better than something as simple as Lynn.

She walked in, firmly shutting the door behind her. Between the built-in anti-surveillance technology and the weekly-refreshed wards, there was scarcely a safer place in the world to speak without being overheard, so she wasted no time in broaching the subject at hand.

“I wanted to talk about Pseudonym's apprentice. Specifically, whether or not she needs to stay at his side after what we're expecting this weekend.”

“The council already voted in favor of letting him try to train her before we dismissed Tori as a lost cause,” Wade said. “In fact, it was a measure you voted in favor of. Why the sudden urge to dispose of her?”

Morgana shook her head quickly, eyes widening as she realized how Wade had taken her words. “Nooooo. No no no. I don't want you to kill her. Shit, Wade, why is that always where your mind goes?”

“I oversee a group of criminals and villains. Murder is the first proposed solution more often than not.” Wade gave a slight shrug by way of apology, then folded his hands on top of the massive desk (far bigger than Ivan’s middle-management one), closed his laptop, and assumed his “I’m listening” face.

“Look, I don’t want to kill her—in fact, I rather liked the girl. She’s smart, she’s got some guts, and she’s able to exercise at least a little self-control. My point was that after the confluence, we’re expecting to have at least a few new recruits to the guild once the dust settles. I know Tori didn’t take well to being trained on her own, but I think, in a classroom environment, she might thrive. Having others going through the same things as she is could be a boon, plus it might get a little competition brewing.”

“The last thing Tori Rivas needs is more incentive to excel,” Wade replied. “On top of an already impressive power, she’s strangely driven in regards to creating new technology. I suspect there’s a reason for it; however, so far my investigations into her past haven’t turned up anything compelling. At least, nothing connected to meta-suits.”

“Did you need a personal tragedy or driving force to build your first meta-suit?” Morgana asked.

“Certainly not. I was driven by scientific curiosity coupled with the desire to test the limits of what my brain could do. But I didn’t have the power to shift into fire. If I had, that would have doubtlessly become the subject of most of my study.”

“Guess Tori is different than you,” Morgana said. “But I wasn’t talking about *her* needing the competition. A bunch of new metas, all at the apprentice level... it might be good to have someone in the group with a head start. Should do a great job of pissing off the rookies and inspiring them to catch up to Tori.”

Wade tilted his head slightly as he mulled over the idea. He unfolded his hands and reopened his laptop, typing away while still keeping his gaze on Morgana. After several seconds of nothing but the clacking of keys filling the air, he finally finished thinking and began to speak.

“You raise valid points, Lynn. Tori could be very useful in getting the new recruits on their feet. Her somewhat abrasive personality would go far in making sure they wanted to surpass her, if nothing else. However, I don’t think we would need to go so far as to separate her from her apprenticeship to Ivan in the process.”

“Are you saying we should have one apprentice under a guild councilor and the rest lumped together in a class? I don’t think that’s going to work quite as well. They won’t see Tori as a true peer, so it won’t light as much of a fire under them when she pulls ahead.” Morgana resisted the urge to put her hands on her hips or show defensive body language. Wade was a reasonable man, the most reasonable she’d ever known, and he was willing to discuss something endlessly so long as he believed the other party hadn’t dug in and shut down.

“It may be less effective; however, I think it’s the best solution all around for several reasons,” Wade said. “Firstly, you forget how many of the guild members still look to Ivan as a legend and leader. Circumstances are irrelevant; the mere fact that he took an apprentice has reignited an interest in many of our members to do the same. I predict most, if not all, of whatever recruits we can scrounge from the confluence will be under a guild teacher before the weekend is over. Thus, they will be in the same situation as Tori, if with somewhat less infamous teachers.”

Morgana nodded her head slowly; Wade was right about how Ivan was viewed. Outside of Balaam and the others who believed no one should be allowed to retire, Ivan was still treated with as much respect and deference as Wade himself. She’d also considered the possibility that he might reignite the trend of taking on apprentices, but she hadn’t expected Wade to be so on board with the idea.

“Secondly, I’m hesitant to put any sort of plan in motion until I see what the components before us are. We may indeed get a large amount of recruits from the confluence; however, we could also come up empty-handed or with very few. It’s certainly happened before. There’s no sense in planning for a situation we don’t know is even going to occur. The third reason I don’t want to separate them is the most important, though.”

Wade paused for a moment, typing a few more things on his computer, and then slightly lowered the screen.

“Right now, Tori’s association with Ivan is both her greatest threat and protection. When we voted before, she was a nameless recruit that no one had interest in. So long as she is in her apprenticeship, only he has the right to kill her. Now that I’ve aligned her with Ivan, Balaam and his faction would vote to have her removed the minute she was up for discussion. The vote last time was too close—only apathy kept her alive, a protection she no longer possesses.”

“I get it,” Morgana said. “Tori Rivas either finishes her apprenticeship under Ivan, or she won’t live to have any other chance.”

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## Chapter 13

Thunder rattled the house although no sounds of rain joined it. The only accompaniment, besides the continuous blasts of lightning, was the barking of the neighborhood dogs, yelping enthusiastically with every boom of sound. Ivan left the kitchen with a glass of sweet tea and a can of beer, the latter of which he set down before Tori.

“Is it okay for us to just be eating dinner like this?” Tori accepted the drink and eyed her plate of pasta hungrily, but at the same time, she couldn’t shake the feeling that something was off. “I mean, with shit about to go down at any given minute and all?”

“A confluence is a gathering of forces,” Ivan reminded her. “This strange storm front may well be one of them, but on its own, it poses no more danger than any other sky full of clouds. Even once the confluence starts, it’s not as though a buzzer will sound and chaos will descend upon the city. Only those aware of what’s happening and the few caught up in the side effects will ever realize what has transpired.”

Tori popped open her beer and took a sip. It was still cold, despite the tension in her gut about all the impending unknowns. Ivan’s lessons on control were definitely taking; Tori couldn’t remember the last time she drank something while nervous and didn’t accidentally heat it up.

“That seems kind of far-fetched. You all made it sound like powers would just be raining from the sky.” Tori got the words out before another clap of thunder drowned her out, but only barely.

“Let me put it this way: before you joined the guild, you had never heard of a confluence. You’d never even suspected such things existed, because the only aftermath is an influx of new metas, which both we and the capes manage carefully. So, if someone as smart as you never put together that metas were often created en masse, why would you suspect mundane minds to be capable of piecing it together?”

“Using my own ego against me, that’s a low blow.” Tori speared a large bite of pasta and promptly wolfed it down before continuing. “I did notice the grouping, though; most people do. We just associate it with the big events that create lots of metas. Stuff like the discovery of that magical city beneath Indianapolis, the alien ship that blew apart and scattered debris across Nevada, and, of course, the original explosions at Wilshire Applied Technologies back in the forties. All were big events that saw the rise of people with new powers, and I’m guessing all occurred during confluences.”

“Some, but possibly not all,” Ivan said. “New metas spring up outside of confluences all the time. This is just when we see a wide range created at once.”

“That’s good.” Tori stabbed at her food with a bit more gusto this time then quickly reeled in the pasta violence. It was almost a subtle enough change for Ivan to miss it. “I’d hate to think people were on watch every time a chemical lab blew up or an experiment went awry but chose to do nothing because they wanted more metas in the world.”

“You sat in on the council meeting where we made plans to deal with the impending confluence. As of right now, you see exactly how much information we have to work with,” Ivan told her. “Do you feel as though we can do much to alter however this will play out?”

“Nope. Feels like we’re going to end up being caught flat-footed, dicks in our hands, and have to scramble to do what little damage control we might manage.”

“That’s a crude and somewhat inaccurate analog—”

Ivan was interrupted by another clap of thunder, this one so powerful that his dishes rattled across the table. From outside, he and Tori both saw a bolt of what appeared to be purple lightning strike the street, lingering longer than any bolt of true electricity would. Before the thunder’s echoes had fully faded, they were both out the door, spilling out into the street along with the rest of the neighborhood.

The asphalt was warped and melted where it had been struck, and Ivan held his breath as he waited for some manner of animated road

monster to pull itself into being. After a few heartbeats, it seemed that the lightning hadn't been enhanced, or at least wasn't that powerful. Ivan let the air slowly slip from his lungs. Tori tapped him on the shoulder, softly at first, but with increasing fervor until he finally followed her gaze skyward.

Overhead, the dark clouds of the impending storm were colliding with strangely-colored smoke from one of the corporate laboratories outside the bounds of Ridge City. Multi-colored veins crept through the clouds, arching in irregular patterns as they wove through dark swells of rain and lightning.

Ivan could feel threads of magic up there, weaving about amid the warping storm. He wasn't entirely sure why, but it didn't matter. Understanding the cause was a job for after the dust had settled. From the growing chatter among his neighbors, it seemed this wouldn't be one of the low-key confluences. People knew something was up, and that would put them on edge.

"We should get inside," Ivan announced, as much to the people around him as to Tori, who he took lightly by the shoulder. "Whatever that stuff is doing, the strike was too close for us to be out here in a lightning storm."

The chatter seemed to swell with consensus, and to his relief, Ivan saw many of his neighbors follow his lead and head back into their homes. Right now, the guild members on standby would be getting prepped; he and Tori weren't due for a shift until the following night. That didn't mean he might not be needed before then, though. Until Ivan was called in, the best he could do was encourage his neighbors to stay safe and make sure he had privacy to work.

Ivan slammed and locked the door behind him as another clap of thunder tore through the sky, followed by the soft patter of raindrops finally slapping against his roof.

Just like that, the storm was upon them.

\* \* \*

She flung open the attic door and was nearly pushed back by the wind screeching through what had been a window only moments before. The rain soaked her clothes as she struggled to find something to block the hole with. The lightning had struck through a window, of all things, and as another bolt flashed outside, a glimmer of light among the boxes it had struck and charred caught her eye.

Kicking aside the smoky remains and debris, she uncovered a strange pendant. It was silver, with runes etched across it and some sort of creature in the center. One of her great-grandmother's "treasures," no doubt. The woman could have been on that hoarding show if it had been around when she was alive. There was always someone in the family who said they were going to tackle the boxes in the attic and see if she had left behind anything valuable, another bit of real worth aside from what was already lost, yet somehow it never got done.

The wind and rain seemed less important the longer she stared at the pendant. Everything around it was burned or destroyed, but this was completely unharmed. Her delicate fingers brushed against the surface, and she almost drew away in surprise at how warm the silver object was. In fact, she tried to pull back, but her body wouldn't listen. Her hand wrapped around the pendant, lifting it reverently from the ground as water continued to pelt her. It had gone from warm to hot in the span of seconds, and as she stared at the curious bobble, she saw a flicker of movement.

That creature in the center had flinched, moving its long scaly head so that silver eyes were staring into her own. Wings stretched from its back and a spiny tail whipped about from behind. The burning of the metal had gone from hot to unbearable, yet she could have no more let go than she could have torn off her own hand.

A clap of thunder drowned out her first scream, but not any of those that followed.

\* \* \*

He staggered through the street, trying to let out a yell of pain and instead releasing only a high-pitched roar. The windows of nearby cars cracked at the sound, but he paid them no attention. The pain in his body, the shifting of his bones and the growing of mass, it was all too much to

bear. Despite lobbying against gun ownership for most of his adult life, he'd happily have put one in his mouth at that moment if it would have made the pain stop.

A crunching sound reached his ears and he realized he'd hip-checked a car, the feeling so minor that it hadn't even registered. The car, on the other hand, had a serious dent and looked like it had been shoved away from the curb. A low moan escaped his lips, and he pushed onward.

Overhead, he could see streaks in the air, along with a strange cloud that was sending out oddly-colored lightning bolts. Probably metas—or, rather, *other* metas. That thought was bitter as it scorched across his brain, but there was no denying what was right in front of him. Whatever was in that drug he'd taken, it was clearly not FDA approved. All this because of his damn blown-out knee. Now he not only wasn't going to play football again, he'd be lucky if they let him back in his college.

"You look like hell," said a man hovering a few feet in the air. He was golden in hair, clothing, and the glow that emanated from him. Landing gently on the drenched sidewalk, the man approached, showing no concern for the monstrosity facing him.

"Ap-ol-lo." Words didn't want to form with this strange new tongue, but he forced them out anyway. This was Apollo, one of the greatest champions in the world. If anyone knew what was happening, could help him, it was Apollo.

"That's right, I'm the great Apollo. And you seem like you could use a hand."

\* \* \*

People were crawling away from the debris slowly but steadily. She'd been farther back than most of them, never much of a fan of poetry readings. Her job was just to pour the coffee while customers piled up on the couches and listened to people read. No one had expected that weird guy's book to start glowing, for him to read in a strange, twisted language that seemed to carve its way through her ears. She still wasn't sure if it was the lightning or him that had created the explosion, but from the remains of his cheap boots still smoking on the stage, she was betting on the latter.

The weird flash, though, and that wave that had burst forth from him... those were beyond insane. She shook her head, refusing to let herself get distracted, not while crawling through a half-destroyed coffee shop with a torrential rainstorm spewing down around them. Pushing forward, she stumbled to her feet and glanced in what remained of the rear wall's mirror.

Soot covered her face and stained her short white-blond hair, but she didn't see any serious injuries. She looked a fright, but that was nothing compared to what some were dealing with. Besides, with a good shower and a little time at the hospital, she might just be able to walk out of this.

"I'll be fine," she muttered to herself, turning away to look at the rest of the people still trapped. "Fit, fine, and right as rain."

The words had barely left her mouth when the storm moved inside, relentless drops pelting her and the others as though they were lying on the ground outside. It washed over her, sending her stumbling back to trip over one of the cushioned chairs. She huddled behind it, shutting her eyes tightly and praying that this night would end soon.

"Chin up," she reminded herself. "You can do this; it's always darkest before the dawn."

Screeches filled the air as the last of the emergency lights cut out, leaving everyone stranded in inky black darkness.

\* \* \*

Nexus stood on top of the Quincy Hotel, seemingly unaware of the raindrops soaking his coat and the thin body beneath it. At this altitude, he was technically at risk for being struck by lightning, but that didn't worry him. On the rare occasions it happened, he'd always made arrangements to be elsewhere just before impact. Besides, this was one of his favorite events. He tried to get a good seat each time it happened.

Not that it always did, of course. The multiverse was sprawling, technically infinite, though after a certain point, the worlds were so far removed from his that they were essentially alien and therefore uninteresting. Still, in the core worlds he visited, this storm almost always

happened. The causes changed, and with them the effects, but in some form or fashion, this storm would soak Ridge City.

Though there was ample entertainment throughout the night, the real fun would begin once the sidewalks dried and the sun hung overhead. So many new people with gifts previously unseen. So many new possibilities for how they would be used and eventually use others. Nexus had seen it play out in countless worlds already, and there were countless more to witness, but this was a show he was especially excited about.

After all, this world had not one but two wholly unique people in it, unseen anywhere else in the multiverse. Nexus was quite anxious to see how they would play these new cards being dealt to them. Perhaps good would triumph; more likely it would be evil, but no matter how things went, he would be entertained.

And when someone was in a situation like his, that was the component they cared the most about.

\* \* \*

“Aaaaaand done!” Donald’s voice rang through his apartment, partially drowned out by the sound of pounding rain, but he made the announcement nonetheless. Despite the rain, he could hear the soft hum of power as his new system came fully online for the first time. It hadn’t been an easy endeavor; half the parts he used were either custom or personally modified to make them function as needed. But now, at long last, Donald was finally going to see the fruits of his efforts.

All three screens flickered to life as he sank into his worn but sturdy chair. Behind him, a blue light glowed from his system’s massive new power source, casting azure light on the rows of electronics lined up on either side of him. Additional monitors rested directly to his left and right. Although these hadn’t strictly been necessary, he still felt it created a more immersive environment. His hands wove around the custom controllers set up on the armrests of his chair, and before his eyes came the most beautiful sight he’d beheld to that point: the *Legacy World* loading screen, rendered so crisp and clear Donald felt like he could practically reach through the screen and take hold of his character.

“I am sooooo calling in sick tomorrow.” He hoped Tori wouldn’t rat him out when he said he had a stomach bug, but either way, there was zero chance Donald could tear himself away from this new toy so soon. Besides, Tori seemed solid; he doubted she’d tattle.

The hum of his electronics grew stronger as the claps of thunder seemed to come faster and faster. Ordinarily, he would have shut everything down and pulled the cord from the walls, but Donald hadn’t spent all that cash on a power management system to fear something as weak as surges. According to the specs on what he’d bought, it could, and had, been used to regulate entire sections of an old Russian nuclear test site. He couldn’t imagine why they’d been willing to let it go so cheaply, and Donald wasn’t going to pry. He had the equipment, the tech, and now, finally, the power. It was time to reach a whole new level.

When Donald woke up the next morning, he would find out that one of those strangely-colored bolts of lightning had hit his building’s transformer, blowing out the electrical system for the entire complex. Donald didn’t have a chance to register what was happening in the moment, however, as energy burst through his oh-so-foolproof power source, flowing through his gaming array before arcing outward into the nearest conductive source: Donald himself.

The upside was that it all happened so fast that there was no time to register any pain as the bright blue volts struck him from nearly every conceivable direction, filling his body with electricity along with a myriad of other things. When it finally stopped, he slumped over in his chair briefly before tottering forward and slamming his head to the floor.

Eight hours later, when he finally rejoined the land of the living, that bruise on his forehead would be the only injury Donald found.



## Chapter 14

*“As responders continue to comb through the wreckage of a laboratory registered to Granco Pharmaceuticals, the hopes of finding any more survivors are dwindling. Many of those that were rescued have cooperated with investigators, shedding much-needed light on the accident that sent unexpected blasts of multi-colored lightning tearing across Ridge City last night. While much of the information remains classified, confidential sources have said that it all stemmed from yet another attempt to recreate the infamous Wilshire Applied Technologies experiment that gave the world, among many other things, Professor Quantum.”*

Tori muted the television as Ivan walked into the living room with two plates of scrambled eggs and bacon. She'd been stuck to the screen all morning, but it had been more or less a loop of the same information. Occasionally, there would be an interview with a clearly-panicked and lying Granco executive to spice things up, and those Tori was relishing. There was no compassion in her heart for sloppy, irresponsible scientists—a suitable classification for anyone who would try that experiment so near a city. Even Professor Quantum, the world's leading expert on meta-elements (and a testament to them, since his powers were due to high levels of setlium exposure), had moved his work to a remote island in order to minimize possible casualties.

“You ever wonder if the rest of the Science Sentries get pissed when they're lumped together as ‘other things’ every time someone talks about the professor?”

“It's been a long time since I had any dealings with them, but even back then, they weren't particularly fond of living in his shadow,” Ivan replied. “I was in prison when they officially split up as a team, so I can't say for certain as to what drove them apart. I believe the official story was that the others were getting too old, since they didn't get his seemingly endless youth; however, my guess would be that his ego finally succeeded in driving them away.”

“Bit of a prick despite the family-friendly image?” Tori asked.

“Professor Quantum might be the only living person I’ve ever met who is as smart as Doctor Mechanial, and the accident gave him physical powers that put him on par with me. I can’t imagine any situation where a man like that doesn’t turn into some form of asshole.” Ivan took a large bite of eggs, thankful he’d spent the time to dice and add fresh garlic before scrambling them.

“I always imagined most of the big names were assholes when the cameras went off,” Tori said, turning her attention to the bacon before the eggs. “Professor Quantum always seemed like the coldest of them, but I bet Quorum and Lodestar are no better.”

Ivan’s fork scraped the plate ever so slightly. He disguised the twitch of his fingers by digging out an extra-large scoop of eggs. “Quorum is probably the fairest person any of us will ever meet. All those voices give him a lot of perspective. He can be a bit stuffy at times, but truthfully, the man is almost entirely without ego. Not surprising given what his sense of self must be like. As for Lodestar...” Ivan hesitated, unsure of exactly how to put this for his apprentice. The capes were, ostensibly, the enemies, but there wasn’t exactly a bounty of negative things to say about the woman with glowing hair and lavender eyes. “She’s... well, she’s the real deal. Almost every cape I ever met and fought was in it for their own reasons. Even if those reasons led them to do good, the core was driven by some sort of selfishness; they were still people, after all. Lodestar’s a true hero, which makes her the hardest person in the world to fight against. She won’t turn or run or back down, no matter the opponent.”

“Guess some people do live up to the hype. Hope I never have to fight her,” Tori said. She could see something flickering in Ivan’s eyes, though she had no clue whether it was vitriol for the cape who beat him, admiration for such a powerful fighter, or some emotion that was entirely unexpected.

Ivan snorted through a bite of his bacon and shook his head. “There is no situation in which you should try to go up against Lodestar. It’s entirely futile. Words can’t convey what it’s like watching her drop from the sky in an explosion of golden light, the crushing sense of defeat you feel

tearing through you. As soon as we saw that meteor-like drop, we knew it was over.”

“That’s quite a statement, given your track record and acclaim.”

“I’m sure you researched all the footage and articles, so you already know that I could never beat her. Pretty much everyone else, sure, but never her. And that was in my prime. Now, I doubt I’d last more than a minute against her, tops.”

“You still look young and spry to me,” Tori pointed out. She finished off the last remains of her breakfast and idly glanced around to see if Ivan had brought toast.

“My body might not age much, but I haven’t been in a real fight in years. There’s no room for being rusty when going up against one of the greats.”

“Not like she’s been all over the news lately, either. Actually, I can’t remember the last time I saw Lodestar make an actual appearance.”

“No doubt she’s locked herself away to train up the next generation of capes,” Ivan said, perhaps a hair too quickly. “At any rate, since our docket is clear today, I thought we might swing by the guild headquarters and see how the cleanup is going. They say it’s all under control, but there might be some tasks we can assist with. Who knows, perhaps you can even sneak a peek at some of the new recruits.”

“Ooooh, spying, I likey.” Tori set her plate down on the coffee table and checked the screen, which was currently showing the blacked out section of downtown Ridge City. “Any chance we’ll get a four-day weekend out of this?”

“Power should be back on at the office by early afternoon. We’re lucky they let us telecommute the whole day as it is,” Ivan replied.

“Yet we’re not telecommuting at all. You want us to play hooky and go mess around with guild business.”

Ivan rose from the couch and paused to pick up Tori’s dish off the coffee table. “Come on, now, you’ve been at the company for over a week

already. Don't tell me you really think anyone actually telecommutes, especially not on a Friday. This is the corporate equivalent of a snow day."

"And just like during real snow days, I have to spend it inside studying," Tori said. For the briefest of moments, her eyes seemed to grow slightly wistful and a touch sad. Then she blinked and it was gone. She turned quickly to see if Ivan had noticed; he made a point of facing the TV. It certainly didn't fool her, but it allowed them to skate over the moment without comment. To both of them, that was the best way to treat momentary displays of emotion.

"It's not just studying," Ivan corrected. "Since my kids are out of town and the confluence came early, you and I have some free time this weekend. I was thinking that perhaps it's time to start some light combat training."

"Seriously? That's awesome!" Tori leapt up so quickly that she nearly smacked her shin on the coffee table. As fast as the excitement had come, it transformed into concern as she studied her teacher's stoic expression. "Wait, you're not going to try to kill me again, right?"

Ivan smiled and turned toward the kitchen, dishes clinking lightly as he walked.

"'Try' is a bit of a strong word. Let's just say that whatever happens, happens."

\* \* \*

Quorum stood atop the overlook, staring through the one-way glass at the motley collection of people assembled in the sizable room below. Many looked benign, though a few had the telltale signs of recently-transformed metas. One older woman was hovering a few inches off the ground; a child had blue sparks flashing periodically from his eyes. Then there was the seven-foot-tall man who seemed closer to an anthropomorphic beast than a human: head of a tiger, body of a gorilla, talons of an eagle, and that was just what Quorum could make out from up in his vaulted position. Most of them would be able to readjust to their changed lives, having the option either to return to the mundane world they'd known or embrace their potential to be champions of good. The

tiger-headed man, however, would likely get no such option. Whatever path lay ahead for him, the life he'd held before was forever out of reach. Quorum felt for metas like that. After all, he was one.

"Quite a crop this year," said Apollo, walking over with a stack of files in hand. "Most we picked up scared and confused. The only one who did any real damage was Ren Tanaka, and honestly, I can't blame the kid. If I'd been turned into some sort of weird chimera monster, I would have accidentally broken some windows too."

"How are they in terms of power?" Quorum asked calmly. There were certainly more metas out there, ones that hadn't been so distraught or easy to find, to say nothing of those who would stumble upon remnants of the confluence and be created later. Most would be lower-level, not suited for lives donning the cape nor intriguing enough to be courted by Wade Wyatt and his team. The strongest ones usually popped out the first night, though not always. Quorum estimated there would be a few surprises showing up in the weeks to come, perhaps even a determined solo hero in a homemade costume. He was rather fond of the upstarts; they reminded Quorum of how things had been back when they were first beginning. No uneasy alliances, no global organization, just a bunch of people who'd been handed power trying to do the best they could with it.

"We haven't gotten to do any real testing yet," Apollo said. "I've got Stalwart Iron rigging up some dummies in the practice chambers for a baseline physical exam. Surprisingly broad range of origins, though. Several accidentally mutated, as we'd expected from the storm, but there are also a fair amount of activated inner powers and even a few who are testing positive for magic. Data Mine thinks that the people at Granco were employing mystical substances in their experiment."

"That would account for the energy spikes we saw throughout the night," Quorum agreed. "Combining magic with such a high level of experimental technology is bound to produce unexpected results. Do any of them have hope of reversal?"

"A few are showing tangible cores of power. There's more testing to do before we know if it's safe, but separating them from those cores could

return them to human.” Apollo flipped through his folders as he spoke, skimming to make sure the information he provided was accurate.

“I don’t suppose Ren is one of those few.” Quorum already knew the answer; he’d been around for too long not to know how cruelly the world worked.

“Afraid not,” Apollo confirmed. “He was on an experimental drug trying to treat a blown-out knee. We think that’s what the lightning he was hit by reacted with. No one is even sure what it did to him yet; all we know is that his DNA has been seared like a flank steak. Whatever he was before, there’s no way to turn him back from here.”

“Thank you for the update,” Quorum said. “Those people have been kept waiting long enough, I believe. It’s time to start my address. Hopefully I can sway them toward lending us the strength of their talents.”

Apollo closed his files hurriedly as Quorum started down the hall. “You’ll do great. We always have a big crop of recruits after you rally them. Heck, that’s what got me to sign up initially.”

“One never knows just how things will go,” Quorum said. A small smile pulled at the edges of his mouth as he remembered seeing Apollo for the first time over a decade ago. He’d looked much the same as he did now, only with a touch of fear in his eyes where confidence currently dwelled. “I appreciate the encouragement, though. Pay close attention as I talk with them, Apollo. There may come a day when you are the one who must greet the new metas.”

“I could only hope to be a pale shadow of you, sir.” There was nothing small or soft about the smile blazing on Apollo’s face as he trailed down the hall after Quorum.

\* \* \*

“Only three?” Tori didn’t bother masking her disappointment as Xelas told them the results of the previous night’s storm. “I thought there would be, like, a whole new litter of meta-humans out there.”

“Oh, no doubt there’s a shitload,” Xelas replied. Despite her metallic form, her voice was warm and lively, probably the most carefree Tori had

heard in her time with the guild. “But the capes are the ones who scoop up most of them. We usually only run into ones that are on, or building toward, a rampage near something we’re protecting. Capes play offense, we play defense. It means we get fewer, sure, but ours are more destructive.”

“Are there any of particular note?” Ivan asked.

“They’re all fairly neat. One guy keeps accidentally creating powerful spells and wards by drawing simple symbols, another summons swarms of insects, and then there’s a woman with a transforming power. In the two hours we’ve had her, she’s done two distinct but similar shifts. Arcanicus thinks that’s barely scratching the surface. She even put some hurt on Thuggernaut before he was able to take her down.”

Ivan gave a slight nod while Tori let out a long whistle. “Thuggernaut? That massive guy who looked like he could crush me between his fingers when I met him? That’s who this new gal beat up?”

“Thuggernaut is a good man with a firm head on his shoulders, but technically speaking, he’s not the most powerful of metas,” Ivan informed her.

“Still, for a rookie to leave a mark like she did, the lady is working with serious mojo,” Xelas added. “Doc is out testing the lot of them right now, using a different suit than his usual.” She turned to Tori, since this comment was clearly for her benefit rather than Ivan’s.

“Since these folks didn’t get caught busting into a vault, they still get a choice before joining,” Xelas continued. “The ones who have control and want normal lives are cut free; typically we tell them we’re a group of metas who like to help newbies figure things out. The ones who have control and who Doc thinks will go criminal are joining whether they like it or not; that’s part of what the guild is here for. The ones who don’t have control, but he believes will be able to attain it, are given a little more information to work with. They can either sign on and get training, be cut loose to try and live normally, or go work for the capes. However, they are also given a firm warning that if they lose control and we have to deal with them, it’s going to be in a permanent fashion. Getting turned into a meta isn’t their fault, but choosing to be a loose cannon around others is.”

“Geez, you all really don’t fuck around,” Tori said. “Also, someone besides Pseudonym calls Doctor Mechaniacal ‘Doc’? Is this an old-friend thing, or can any guild member use the cutesy nickname?”

“Perks of having known him for long enough and being on the council,” Xelas shot back. Her robotic features had no trouble relaying heaps of smarmy sarcasm in the grin she flashed Tori. “Put in enough years of service, and maybe you can get away with it too.”

Ivan cleared his throat to bring Xelas’s attention back around to him, though the devious sparkle remained in her mechanical eyes. “Since Doctor Mechaniacal and the new recruits are out, I assume Tunnel Vision is on the property?”

“Sure, they’re in the break room down the hall.” Xelas motioned out the door of her small, cramped office into a winding hallway of dark carpets and strange people. Tori had barely been able to keep from swiveling her head about as she and Ivan marched in from the parking garage. There weren’t a whole lot more people than she’d seen on her first night, but each one was fascinating and unique enough to warrant a good stare.

“Thank you,” Ivan replied. “If Doctor Mechaniacal returns, let him know that Tunnel Vision has taken us out to one of the training grounds.”

“Roughhousing? Ooo ooo! Can I come watch?”

Tori waited for her teacher to say no, to tell this metal woman that such sessions were meant to be a sacred act of learning between master and disciple. Instead, Ivan gave a half-shrug and waved for Xelas to follow as they walked out her office door.

“I am so glad I had my optic cameras upgraded last week,” Xelas crooned, so excited that she was weaving as they meandered through the halls. “There’s just something magical about the first time you watch a rookie get demolished.”



## Chapter 15

Ivan ducked nimbly to the side. The blast of flame careened harmlessly over his head as Tori scrambled to get a new line of sight on him. From a nearby cluster of rocks, Xelas hooted loudly, the sound of her applause like trash cans being slammed together in a compactor. Tori bitterly wondered how long she was going to keep cheering. They'd been at it for half an hour and she'd yet to so much as even singe the lining on Ivan's costume, let alone land a clean hit. When she went in for melee, he easily tossed her aside, and when she tried to snipe him at a range, he dodged the fireballs like he had all the time in the world.

"Can we pause for a minute?" Tori asked, phasing into her human-form. Overhead, the sun beat down on them, making the dry sand around them so hot that it likely would have been intolerable if one weren't partially made of fire, entirely mechanical, or a goddamned legendary powerhouse. She didn't know where they were, but Tunnel Vision (a pair of fraternal twins who shared one code name) had evidently taken them somewhere set aside for guild training. It made sense that they'd be out here—not even Ivan could do more than turn the big rocks into smaller rocks.

"Your enemies won't give you any quarter just because you're tired," Ivan replied, standing stoically as he carefully watched his student.

"I'm not tired, ass. I'm just not sure what I'm supposed to be getting from this." Tori could barely feel the weight of her own costume resting on her body. It breathed in a way she'd never found a fabric capable of. "Yeah, you're a lot faster and stronger than me. Does me firing pointlessly at you for hours really have a point? Shouldn't you be attacking me a little too?"

"Unfortunately, I'm not yet confident that you could survive one of my attacks," Ivan said. "As for the futility of training, did you imagine you'd close the gap between us in such a short time? The best way to improve at fighting is like any other task: do it relentlessly. You have to *find* a way to hit me, whether through creative tactics or increasing your core

abilities. Either way, there's no better training than doing the task. Even in failure, you'll still grow stronger for the effort spent."

Tori idly conjured then released a fireball in her hand as she mulled over Ivan's words. Essentially, fighting him was like trying to play a video game with the difficulty cranked up to maximum. She probably wouldn't beat it anytime soon, but after enough time, the easier modes would seem ludicrously simple. The idea wasn't necessarily flawed, though one glaring problem did stick out to her.

"If that's the case, then shouldn't we be doing this once I have my actual costume?" Tori gestured to the dark, layered material she had worn upon entering the guild's halls. "We both know I want to build a meta-suit. That's the kind of villain I'm going to be. Why not train me how to fight with one of those, instead of with my fire abilities, since I never plan to use them?"

"The girl has full elemental phasing *and* she wants a meta-suit? I can't tell if that's spoiled or ambitious." Xelas tilted her head and tapped her cheek several times. "I'll go with ambitious, since she said she intends to build her own."

"Intentions are well and good, but I can't train you on something that might or might not one day exist," Ivan replied. "Aside from which, the world is an unpredictable, dangerous place. Even if you have no intention of using these abilities for whatever reasons you've dreamed up, there may come a day when they are the only thing that will keep you alive. Better to have the skills and not need them than need them and not have them."

"Thanks for the cliché, Pop Pop. I'd still rather be training with the actual gear I'm going to be spending my life building and using."

"Well then, I'll make you a deal," Ivan said. "Once you have successfully constructed a meta-suit, feel free to bring it to our training sessions. In fact, any equipment you make is fair game..."

Ivan's words tapered off as Tori bolted through the desert sands until she reached the small pile where they'd set their duffels. He had brought along water, bandages, and some minor painkillers in case of emergencies. Tori quickly unzipped her bag and produced what looked like a gauntlet

made of wires, sheet metal, and duct tape. In moments, she'd fastened it to her right arm and was scrambling to get back into position.

"Made this in my downtime," she said, answering a question no one had asked. "Doctor Mechanical was kind enough to provide me with a workspace and some materials in my apartment. It's just a prototype, you understand. I'll need much higher-end tech to create a model that will hold up long-term."

"She's confident," Xelas said. "Pseudonym, you got yourself a fun apprentice. I'm a little jealous."

"Would that I could hand her over to you," Ivan muttered. "Very well, Apprentice, I am a man of my word. You may now use that new piece of equipment in our exercises for however long it holds up. Can we finally resume your training now?"

"Hell yeah!" Tori slapped a few buttons and switches with her left hand and the gauntlet softly but audibly buzzed. Flexing her fingers, the glove piece moved, albeit stiffly. As Ivan watched, the dark material of the glove began to glow, turning from a rust color to hot red-white, like a sword pulled fresh from the forge. It was certainly an interesting spectacle, he would give her that.

Ivan slid carefully into a defensive position, eyeing his apprentice closely as he waited for her attack. Though it didn't seem so compared to his skills, Tori was actually a reasonable combatant already. It was true that she couldn't hurt him, but dodging her attacks without tapping into too much of his power actually demanded some attention on Ivan's part. Taking the fireballs head-on wouldn't teach her anything, so right now he was focused on improving her ability to land shots.

Tori licked her lips as she raised her right hand and took aim. No subtlety in her approach, but he supposed that was to be expected when using a piece of untested equipment. From the size of the thing, Ivan was guessing it would send a bigger blast of fire at him, augmenting her existing power. It was the smartest way to utilize what she had to get what she wanted.

The white beam that shot out from Tori's hand was roughly as thick as a soda can and moved so quickly that Xelas would have to replay it at a sixteenth of its actual speed for others to see what had happened. To those who didn't have trained or enhanced senses, there was merely a flash, then a brief motion as Ivan stepped back, and a line of glass that suddenly materialized between Pseudonym and his apprentice.

Ivan felt power surge through his veins before he even registered the threat. Time slowed as his eyes took on their trademark almost-entirely-black appearance, his magical energy reacting to the impending danger. He could see the beam scorching through the air, set on a course for his chest. She hadn't pulled any punches, and for some reason, Ivan felt a flicker of pride at that fact. He could have avoided it entirely, but Ivan's curiosity was piqued. If it had triggered his power, the beam must have been something notable. As her teacher, it was practically his duty to test what she could do.

The beam struck him square in the shoulder, slamming into him like a burning hammer. It was so forceful that Ivan felt himself take a single step backward under the assault. Then it was over, and Tori was stripping off the gauntlet hurriedly as it smoked and popped, a meltdown already beginning.

For his part, Ivan carefully examined the patch of sand that had been turned into glass from the cast-off heat, and then checked his shoulder. The fabric had been cleanly burned through, but his skin was largely unblemished. At the center of the circle, however, there was a small red spot. He touched it delicately and nearly winced in surprise. No doubt about it; that was a burn. As the spot faded, Ivan looked over at Tori, who had successfully freed herself from the glove before it began throwing off sparks like a busted transformer.

She had managed to wound him with that garage-made device. Granted, he hadn't been using any shields or wards, but it was still impressive. Untested and untrained though she was, Tori had done something entire legions of capes had failed to accomplish: put a wound on Ivan's flesh.

"Hot holy damn!" Xelas yelled from her perch on the rocks. "That one is going in the Christmas highlight reel."

\* \* \*

Chloe sat in the back of the small room, quietly filling small Styrofoam cups with dark coffee as she pretended not to listen. The people gathered around in metal folding chairs paid her no mind; they were used to half-concealed eavesdropping and lingering stares. After all, if being a meta-human was easy, they wouldn't need support groups.

"I made it to a third date with the girl I told you all about," said a man wearing a battered toupee. His announcement was greeted by soft applause, and a light blush filled his round cheeks.

"She knows I'm a meta, though I haven't told her exactly how it works yet. I'm planning to tell her on our next night out. If you see me coming to extra meetings next week, you'll know the reason why." He chuckled anxiously and touched his toupee unconsciously. Chloe wondered what secrets the patch of fake hair was hiding as the others chattered with assurances that things would go well.

She wasn't quite sure why she'd volunteered to provide the coffee for this meeting. Yes, Ridge City Grinders did have a reputation for giving back to the local community, but that wasn't why she felt uncertain. Truthfully, Chloe was chiding herself for being too much of a coward to just own up to what had happened and take a seat at one of those metal folding chairs. She'd created a convenient lie to come here while the coffee shop was being fixed, or at least made workable, because she didn't want to admit to anyone, even herself, what the previous night's storm had done to her.

Her hands wavered slightly, and she focused on not talking. Not a mumble, or a whisper, or a word. Chloe had yet to figure out what caused the strange occurrences around her, but more often than not, they came after she spoke. Until she had control, or at least understanding, she was doing her best to stay mute.

Chloe Henson refused to be beaten by mere blackouts, explosions, and strangely-oriented rain. She'd get the hang of what was going on, sooner or later. Chloe wasn't ready to resign herself to one of those chairs.

Not until she knew for sure just what had happened to her.

\* \* \*

“That is... impressive.” Wade watched the video once more, carefully examining each detail, from the speed of the beam to the transformation of each grain of sand. On the desk next to the television sat the remains of Tori’s gauntlet. Ivan stood behind him, eyeing the video as Wade rewound and advanced to various parts. “There are flaws, of course. The beam’s power isn’t nearly constricted enough if it let out sufficient heat to turn the sand to glass. Speed could use work, as well. With that much blasting power, she could get it at least fifty percent quicker. And, of course, the fact that it burned out after a single shot speaks to some serious longevity issues. Overall, though, it’s quite an impressive accomplishment.”

“Impressive would be if she’d had a month and real tools,” Ivan said. “Not a week of spare nights and a miniature junk shop above my garage.”

“Now, now, I did provide some quality components for her to use,” Wade replied, rewinding the tape once again. “True, I wasn’t certain what she’d be able to do with them, but I wanted to give her a chance.”

Ivan walked around to the front of Wade’s desk. Unlike his office at Indigo Technologies, the desk Wade sat at here didn’t sit in front of a glass wall that provided an excellent view. Instead, there were bits of tech scattered about the room, as well as a pile of half-finished inventions on Wade’s desk. Ivan often remarked that Wade was as messy as he was brilliant, which was a remarkably high bar on both accounts.

“Wade, you need to shoot straight with me here. Did you give her anything that accounts for being able to build something that powerful? She managed to burn me, *me* of all people. I might not have been at full power, but I was definitely braced for the blow. If she could churn out something like that...” Ivan’s voice trailed off as the implication flooded his mind. He could count on one hand the number of people who could build a device like that so quickly, and one of them was standing on the opposite side of the desk from him.

“When I first brought Ms. Rivas to your attention, I mentioned her powerful intellect,” Wade said. “From the moment I began testing her, it became clear that her greatest limitations have always been finances and resources. Given appropriate funding, your apprentice would have likely

already constructed a meta-suit that would put my first generation ones to shame.”

Ivan ran a hand through his dark hair and leaned against the edge of the metal desk, turning his eyes to the television once more. “You said she was smart, but that’s like Thuggernaut saying someone is tall. You’re both towering so far above most everyone else that it seems like you’re guessing at what everyone else’s standards are.”

“Then let me clarify: Tori Rivas is smart by my definition of the word. Her technological prowess rivals any that I’ve ever seen. She still has much to learn and a long road before her, but I have no doubt she could be an inventor of legendary stature one day. Perhaps her creations will even eclipse my own.” Wade clicked off the television and picked up the smoking husk of her gauntlet.

“So why in the nine hells aren’t you her teacher? Think of what that woman could do with a real scientist leading her.”

“She doesn’t need scientific guidance.” Wade juggled the gauntlet, causing a slight tinkling sound to fill the room. “That was proven by her little side-project here. If I train Tori, she will become a second generation version of me. She possesses the potential to be much more than a poor copy; she can be a powerful entity all her own. To get there, however, she needs to learn about more than science. Did you know that Tori was up for three grants during her time in high school?”

“It didn’t come up over dinner,” Ivan said.

“Each time, she was the frontrunner but refused to comply with the requirement that would split a percentage of credit and income for her discoveries with the grant’s investors. She has chosen to walk the path of poverty and crime rather than allow anyone else to have claim over her creations.”

“Sounds a lot like someone I know, someone who got pissed at a company for stealing his designs and decided to wipe out their assets by force.” Ivan could still remember the first time he’d seen Doctor Mechaniacal in action—lasers blasting, energy missiles singing through the

air, the high-pitched squeal of his sonic stun gun tearing at people's ears. It had been all he could do to resist fighting him right then and there.

"Precisely. Tori and I are too similar. Under your guidance, she will become a more adult, independent version of herself. Under mine, she would likely end up following in my footsteps, which is pointless. The world already has a Wade Wyatt. I think it would be better off experiencing a Tori Rivas at her true capacity."

"That's all nice and well-intentioned, but look at what she made." Ivan tapped the side of the gauntlet lightly, causing a piece to fall to the ground. "We can't ignore that. Think about what she could do with real resources. It's criminal to make her piss away time with me when she should be pursuing her true calling, and not the kind of 'criminal' that we actually enjoy."

"No, you're quite right there," Wade agreed, setting down the gauntlet before Ivan could do any more damage. "I gave her a few coins and she returned with a golden harp. Ms. Rivas has proven her innovation and intelligence to a degree that even I wasn't expecting. It's high time we allowed her to start constructing that meta-suit she's always going on about. The materials will be pricey, but I don't mind putting them on loan until she begins to earn for the guild."

"Perfect." Ivan walked over and sat forcefully in one of the chairs next to Wade's desk. "We can keep the apprenticeship going, but I'll have her move into guild quarters where she can have a proper lab. As soon as Xelas is done showing her around, we can give her the good news."

Wade took a seat behind the desk. This was not done out of a need to show Ivan which of the two of them was in charge, but because it put a large, heavy object between Wade and his friend. "Actually, there's no need for that. As I mentioned, Ms. Rivas did better than I expected, but I realized she might need a true workspace from the first time we met."

"What did you do?" Ivan's eyes narrowed and he gripped the edge of the desk.

"Nothing too extreme; we merely had a lab built for Ms. Rivas at your residence. It locks from your side and has every safeguard you can



think of. She could set off anything short of a nuke and it wouldn't singe your wallpaper."

"Uh huh. And why haven't I noticed this lab anywhere around my house?" Ivan's irises hadn't vanished yet, but darkness was beginning to creep slowly through his sclera.

"Well, obviously, because we put it in the basement," Wade replied.

"I don't have a... Wade, what did you *do*?"

Wade coughed lightly, a signal that activated many of the defensive measures he'd set up throughout the office. "Since we had the opportunity when we were renovating your garage and moving Tori in, I may have left behind some bots to construct a basement that would make a suitable laboratory. It can be stocked with everything your apprentice needs by day's end."

"Just so we're clear—" Ivan stood up, the entirety of his eyes now cloaked in darkness with only the glowing red runes remaining "—you violated my house without permission, left your little builder-bots around to do whatever they pleased, and built a subterranean level without so much as consulting me?"

"I also took the liberty of stocking a few initial components while we were having this chat," Wade added. If it was going down, he might as well get everything settled at once.

"Get your suit and call Tunnel Vision," Ivan instructed. "We need to have a... *chat*... about the importance of personal boundaries."

## Chapter 16

Tori walked into Monday's weekly meeting tired, sore, and exhausted, yet it was still the most cheerful any of the staff had seen her since her arrival. Training with Ivan had been a wearying experience, but it had all been worth it when he showed her the secret basement tucked under the house. She wasn't entirely sure why he had seemed so grumpy as he'd given her the tour, but the moment she'd set eyes on her new workstation, Tori hadn't cared enough to try and guess.

It was gorgeous—barrels and buckets of parts, along with a computer that could actually handle her calculations and software. There had even been a piece of decoration, the gold-frame painting of Tori and her parents she'd requested to have returned. While Ivan had plodded about like he'd never seen the basement before, Tori dove headfirst into exploring, cataloguing, and—most importantly—planning. She'd barely gotten any sleep. Ivan had to drag her away for Sunday's combat training, and he had actually cut her off from lab access at ten that night so she would get a few hours' rest before they had to go back to work. Her brain had been buzzing, though, and while Ivan could stop her from physically tinkering, he couldn't do a thing about her making sketches in her head.

Tori was still riding the high of mentally solving how to couple together her forearm and bicep joints when Donald plopped into the cubicle next her. Like Tori, he looked as though the weekend had taken a bat to him. Unlike Tori, he wasn't surfing a wave of possibility and endorphins as he sluggishly logged in to his work computer.

"Good morning," Tori greeted cheerfully. "How was the weekend of raiding? Get back up to the max level?"

"Uggggggggghhhh." Donald's head tilted forward slowly until it fell against the top of his small desk with a slight thud. "Stupid, damned, evil, wicked, horrid, villainous, total dickhole of a storm torched my building's electrical system and every item that was plugged in at the time, including my new setup."

Tori sucked in a gasp of air through her teeth, then let it out slowly as she said, “Shiiiiiiiiit. Were you able to salvage anything?”

“Not so much as a RAM stick,” Donald said, his face still smushed on the desk. “I went from having the best gaming set-up in the state to playing all weekend on my three-year-old backup laptop. Yes, my backup one, because I had my main wired in for additional processing power. I just *had* to get that extra burst of speed. Hubris, thy name is Donald Moss.”

“Maybe it’s a chance to start over, you know? Build something even grander than before?” Tori didn’t have a lot of hope that this would cheer him up; she knew a shitshow situation when she saw one.

“And until then, I will clack away on my tiny keyboard like a total noob.” Donald let out a grunt and pulled himself up, quickly logging on to the corporate system. Sad as he might be, getting dinged for being late wouldn’t make it any better. “Still, it wasn’t a total loss,” he muttered at a volume he thought was inaudible.

“How so?”

Donald froze at Tori’s question, quickly stumbling through an array of falsehoods, each more intricate than the last, before realizing he could hide his mistake in the truth. “Well, I still got to play at least, and my guild was able to log some serious levels. We even got enough intel to make a real attempt on one of the raid dungeons next weekend.”

It was clear Donald was hiding something; anyone with half a brain could expend two seconds of effort and crack through the sweaty, uncertain veneer he had built up. Tori decided not to push it, though. Whatever Donald was actually thankful for, it seemed like it was something he dearly didn’t want to talk about. Probably a “personal” folder that was salvaged or backed-up before the system crashed.

“Just goes to show, you don’t need top-of-the-line stuff to have fun with your friends,” Tori said, her leftover pep adding an unexpected tone of encouragement to her trite line.

“Completely true,” Donald agreed.

Though the sentiment was quite accurate, neither one was currently ascribed to the philosophy of minimalism. Tori was focused on perfecting her suit, and Donald... well, Donald desperately needed to get a better setup and probably some peripherals.

The part of his weekend he wasn't sharing with Tori had turned owning such equipment from a desire into a requirement.

\* \* \*

One man hurried down the street, three cups of coffee from the wrecked shop nearby clutched in his hands as he got into the passenger side of an idling sedan. He handed two of the cups to the other men who had been waiting, then glanced around nervously to see if anyone in the bustling downtown area had taken notice of him. No one had, as they were all busy going about their day, most of them inconvenienced by the fact that their de facto coffee destination was under repairs and only had a small stand at the front to serve the swarms of caffeine-starved workers.

"What are we supposed to be watching for, anyway?" said the man in the back seat, sipping tentatively at the still-steaming coffee.

"Just watching," said the driver. "Getting a sense of the comings and goings in the building. We have to figure out when things are the slowest, but there are still enough people. That's when we'll want to strike."

"Seems like a lot of work to rob an office." The man who had brought the coffee continued to watch people as he spoke. With the amount of money on the line for this gig, he was damn sure going to do a good job.

"It's a weird scheme," agreed the driver. "But this is the place he wants hit. Something about corporate espionage, I think. For what he's paying, I didn't ask too many questions."

The backseat rider took another long sip and stared up at the building. "Are you sure we should be trusting this guy?"

"If you want to walk away, feel free. More money all around," said the passenger.

“I’m not quitting, just saying... I don’t know, whole thing seems weird.”

“In this town, weird comes with the highest paycheck,” said the driver. “Now, watch people’s movements. We’ve only got a couple of weeks before he wants to do the job.”

With a long draw of his coffee, the man in the back seat turned his attention to the sizable office building that hosted multiple companies, hundreds of employees, and, unbeknownst to them, one retired super-villain of global infamy.

\* \* \*

Ivan was unsurprised to find Wade’s seemingly simple silver sedan in his driveway as he pulled in. After their conversation had somewhat lapsed during the “sparring match,” it was clear they still had things to discuss. Plus, Wade had been kind enough to leave a voicemail warning Ivan of his arrival. He sat patiently on Ivan’s porch, rocking back and forth in one of the purchased wooden chairs as though he were nothing more than a friend who had stopped by before the homeowner returned. It was both gracious and prudent, for while the locks on Ivan’s house would do nothing to stop Wade, some of the wards might very well have proven troublesome.

“I’m guessing this means one of us is in trouble,” Tori said.

“Not at all; Doctor Mechanic and I simply have some guild business to discuss.” Ivan popped open his door and Tori followed suit. In moments, Ivan had the house unlocked and had shoed everyone inside, lest they give the neighbors more cause for speculation.

“Tori, why don’t you go work on your suit for a while?” Ivan said. He nodded his head toward the wall where an entrance to the basement had been constructed and hidden, all without his consent. It stirred a bit of anger in him, but he forced himself to let the sentiment go. Ivan and Wade had beaten each other up for the better part of two hours; it was time to put the cause of conflict in the past. Not being able to let go in their world made having any sort of friendship essentially impossible.

“Twenty-three years old and I’m still being sent to my room like a kid,” Tori muttered. She still slid the wall aside, though, hurrying down the stairs to her project below without so much as changing out of her work clothes first.

Wade waited until the door was sealed before settling into one of Ivan’s chairs. “I came with news about the recruits.”

“For the love of... I do not want to kill some stupid rookie just because they had the bad luck to get a power they can’t handle. You have a whole guild of villains, I’m sure one of them can handle it.”

“Actually, there’s no need to dispatch any of them,” Wade replied. “All three have decided to join our organization.”

“Seriously? We never bat a thousand on recruitment runs.” Ivan crossed his arms and leaned against the nearest wall, studying Wade’s face carefully for any signs of falsehood.

“The one who summons swarms is excited about his power and very ambitious about developing it. He doesn’t care where he receives the training. Our symbol-wielding mage is a standard anti-social type, hungry for power, status, and probably more than a little vengeance. Truthfully, we may end up with a code-breaker in him, but he at least gets a shot to show he can handle the responsibility first. Lastly, the woman with the transformation ability is terrified of her powers and wants control above all else. Evidently, she nearly killed a few members of her family by accident before Thuggernaut brought her down. I suggested she head to the nearest AHC headquarters before I offered her a spot, but it seems she has no love for that organization in the slightest. Thus, The Guild of Villainous Reformation has three new apprentices.”

Ivan resisted the urge to groan inwardly at the guild’s full name; he always felt it sounded like a cult more than a gathering of like-minded people. Wade had won out in choosing the name. Ostensibly it was meant to sound like a group of villains trying to find their way to the straight and narrow; the cheeky use of “reformation”, used literally in this case to mean “to make different” rather than with its more common connotation, pleased Wade too much to let it go to waste. He got off on wordplay and hiding in

plain sight. Had it been up to him, Ivan would have chosen a simple, unobtrusive name like “Joe’s Meeting Group.”

“Poor kids. I’d hoped one of them would have better decision-making skills,” Ivan said. “Why’d you feel the need to come out and tell me that, though? I’m not taking on any more damn apprentices, if that’s what you’re after.”

“Perish the thought,” Wade said. “No guild member can have more than one apprentice at a time in the first place, and in the second, all of them are already spoken for.”

“Spoken for? What the hell, no one does the mentorship thing anymore. I only did it as a favor to you.”

“But you still did it, and others in the guild took notice,” Wade replied. “Having an apprentice has become an overnight status symbol. Balaam had officially taken the one who can draw magic symbols almost before I accepted him into the guild. Arachno Bro found much in common with our insect summoner, so he has requested to be his teacher and I approved. As for the dragon woman—”

“Hang on, what’s this about dragons now?” Ivan interrupted.

“Ah, right. Things devolved before I brought you fully up to speed. The young woman who can transform does so into multiple types of dragons. Thus far, she has become a red dragon with extremely hot fire-breath and a green dragon with greatly enhanced physical properties.”

“Versatile,” Ivan noted.

“Quite. At any rate, two people are interested in becoming her teacher: Wildwood and Thuggernaut. As she technically falls under the magic category, Wildwood has a stronger claim, but I wanted to get your input before making an actual call.”

Ivan weighed the options in his head. As a magic user, Wildwood might have a more technical right to the young woman’s education, but that didn’t mean he’d be the better teacher. From what Wade had described, she was functionally a brawler so far, which meant Thuggernaut could probably impart more wisdom about how to use her powers rather than just

understanding their source. It was also true that Wildwood was a trusted confidant of Balaam's, and Ivan wasn't so self-aware that he could be certain he was seeing the issue objectively.

"You're the one in charge of the rookies, you make the call," Ivan said. "Right now, her power is still fresh; it's unlikely anyone can be sure how it will work or max out. Today, Thuggernaut seems like a better fit, but her next dragon-form might be purple with the power of spell-casting, which puts Wildwood back in as a solid teacher. If you had to use something as the criteria for choice, maybe ask them why they want her as an apprentice."

Wade leaned back in the chair and smiled. "Funny, I had a very similar thought. Wildwood sowed some malarkey about wanting to pass the knowledge of magic on to the next generation of capable adepts, but it was clear he was following either orders or a trend. Thuggernaut told me that, after fighting our recruit firsthand, he thought she could be much stronger if properly trained."

"Then you already know Thuggernaut is the better choice," Ivan said.

"I do indeed. But I was curious how you would handle the situation, given your respective associations. Our guild's newest recruits are going to be spending time together during their training. It seemed only prudent to see if your prejudices extended to those even associated with Balaam, as his do to you."

"Relax; just because the kid got snagged by that bastard doesn't mean I hate him. Bad luck can happen to anyone," Ivan uncrossed his arms at last and walked over to his sofa, where he nestled into a comfortable position. "But what's this about them spending time together? It's classes or apprenticeship, not both."

"We haven't had the chance to do both," Wade pointed out. "Some camaraderie could be good for them, build alliances and friendships that will keep them alive later on. Plus, we can use one of the greatest teaching tools ever afforded to mankind."



Ivan grinned as he took Wade's meaning. It was the force that had driven him to fighting endless numbers of capes during his youth, that had caused Wade to work tirelessly in developing cutting edge technology, that defined those born of greatness and those burdened by mediocrity. With four rookies all starting around the same time, it provided a perfect opportunity to use that tool and carve stronger, better people out of them. Ivan's voice came out barely above a whisper, yet the excitement and potential in his tone caused it to carry throughout the entirety of the living room.

"Competition."

\* \* \*

No amount of air fresheners could mask the scent of burned plastic that wafted through Donald's apartment. He was tempted to try candles, but the landlord had a pretty strict policy about open flames, and after already losing his computer system, Donald couldn't emotionally handle being evicted. The charred husk of his beautiful system still sat in the corner of his apartment, likely the reason he was unable to cleanse the smell of melted plastic from his space.

Donald paid the shrine of lost potential no mind as he set up the video camera on his uneven kitchen counter. It was cheap, one he'd bought from the discount bin of a local electronics store, but it would record images and that was all Donald really required for now. He had to create proof, to know for sure he wasn't losing his mind. True, if he were crazy, then his brain could make him see madness on video as easily as in real life, but it was a step forward. That was what he was focusing on: just moving one single step at a time toward acceptance and understanding.

Propping up his lone remaining laptop (aside from the work one that he dared not risk in this experiment), on a wooden TV tray took some time, but Donald refused to rush. This was in part because if something went wrong and he lost this computer, he was going to have to get truly desperate, but also because part of him feared what would happen if he tried this and failed. Or, perhaps worse, succeeded.

He clicked the red button on the camera then hurried back into what he hoped was the proper frame. Upon review, Donald would discover that

he'd actually cropped the top part of his head out of the shot by standing too close. He also wouldn't care because that was the least interesting aspect of the video Donald was about to record.

"Ahem. Hi. Um, my name is Donald Moss. And this, I guess, is trial number one of... well, one so far. If you're watching this and something has happened to me, then things probably didn't go that well. Mom, Dad, Sheila... I love you all."

Nervously shuffling about, Donald debated on where to go from there. He hadn't planned the "just in case" goodbye; this was supposed to be for his eyes only. Still, since he'd already gone down that path, he might as well see it through. The other option was stopping to re-record the introduction, and Donald wasn't sure his willpower would hold up for long enough to allow that.

"Last Friday, I was at my computer when the building was hit by one of the lightning bolts from that lab's weird storm. It fried my system and zapped me unconscious. I thought that was all it did, but the next night, when I was on my game... maybe at this point it's better to show than tell."

Donald leaned over and typed quickly on his laptop's keyboard, pulling up the predetermined program he'd carefully selected for the experiment. With a deep breath and an unsaid prayer, he got everything loaded and prepared to proceed.

"Here goes nothing."

## Chapter 17

“Here are the—and I want you to look up from your desk so you can see my hands—” Tori paused, raising her index and middle finger like bunny ears and then lowering them halfway twice “—*vital* spreadsheets you need for today’s meeting.”

She dropped the stack of paper on Ivan’s desk, far enough away that he had to lean forward to reach it. “You know, some employees actually show me respect, seeing as I’m the one in charge of hiring and firing them.”

“True, but those employees aren’t supposedly family members with attitude problems. If I didn’t give you shit, wouldn’t that seem more suspicious?”

Ivan quickly checked to make sure his office door was closed and then leaned back in his chair. Tori had a point, but as it was the kind of point that let her continue getting away with doing what she wanted, he didn’t trust it. At least she was aware enough to make such cracks out of earshot from the mundane office workers. Much as Tori liked to test boundaries, she clearly knew where the unmovable ones lay.

“Just don’t take it too far. Remember, you’re an intern, and an under-qualified one at that. Even I can only justify so much in the name of nepotism.” Ivan flipped through the sheets carefully, admiring the work. Tori might moan and complain about her boring day job, but even when she was half-assing it, she was still the most competent assistant Ivan had ever worked with. “Also, tomorrow after work you will not be coming home with me. I’ve arranged to have a car with one of Doc’s drivers pick you up from here. If anyone asks, tell them you have to go in for one of your ‘meetings’ and show discomfort. That will likely make them let the topic be.”

“Oh, right; the kiddos are coming to the house again, aren’t they?” Tori had heard very little about Ivan’s children, and she’d made a point not to pry. His warning from her first day was seared in her mind, and as much as she was growing fond of her surly teacher, she didn’t doubt for a minute

that he wouldn't make good on his threat. "Another weekend at the pork plant for me, then. I'll pack a bag tonight."

"No need. You'll be heading to the guild this time. Everything you need will be provided for the weekend. From what I understand, there is quite an array of training planned for you all."

Tori tilted her head and arched an eyebrow. "Sending me to the park to play with the other kids? About time, it's already been two weeks since the confluence. I was wondering when—"

The sound of an explosion filled the air. Through the small window in Ivan's office, Tori saw a bright green blast of light burn through the sky. She looked at her boss and teacher, waiting for him to give her an order, to tell her they needed to get to safety. Clearly some heavy shit was going down, right?

Instead of doing any of those things, Ivan let out a heavy sigh and pulled a small radio from his desk. He clicked it on and an excited, static-filled voice burst forth from the black plastic box.

*"—moving to a shelter on Magnolia and Ave E. To all those just tuning in, there is currently a fight occurring in uptown Ridge City by the Alfred Settler Memorial Plaza. Two men with strange powers just robbed Ridge City Savings & Loan and are currently engaged with Stalwart Iron as they try to make their escape. Again, if you are in the area, please seek a safe place to hide. All those out in the open can go to the just-opened shelter at Magnolia and—oh my goodness! It's Battle Cry, Blunderbuss, and Apollo arriving to assist Stalwart Iron. Such an array of talent and power I personally have never seen—"*

Ivan dialed down the volume knob until the radio was barely audible. "This is going to happen a fair bit for the next few weeks. Lots of new metas out there, testing their powers, figuring out what they can do, you get the idea. Eventually, some will build up big enough heads of steam to try and pull a poorly-planned plot like robbing a bank in the middle of the day. Capes are on high alert, so this is the time when any villain with a brain in their skulls goes deep underground until the capes get complacent."

A knock sounded on the door and Barb, the woman from Human Resources Tori had met during her orientation, poked her head in. Atop it was a small plastic fireman's hat with the words "Safety Officer" emblazoned in yellow letters.

"Hey all," Barb greeted. "I'm sure you heard about the fight going on outside. Nothing to worry about, it was miles away and we got word that it's already wrapped up."

"I had complete faith we'd be evacuated if the situation was otherwise," Ivan replied. "Thanks for keeping us in the loop, though."

Tori could barely manage a nod as Barb ducked out and presumably headed off to the next office in the hallway. She stared at the shut door for several moments before finally forcing her tongue to work again. "You all take this stuff really well. I mean... creepily well."

"We work downtown in the city where the AHC has its global headquarters," Ivan replied. "Between idiot upstarts testing their power, the propensity to use capes in place of cops, and being near the tempting target of the financial district, meta fights are just part of our work week. Especially after a confluence."

"Score one for crashing in the slums, I guess. Nothing to steal means the capes rarely get called out." Tori gazed past Ivan to the world she'd spent too many wasted years in. For an instant, she could practically see the beaten-down warehouse where she'd set up her makeshift lab, but she blinked and it was gone. Strange as her circumstances with Ivan and the guild were, it was all still a big step up from where she'd been not so long ago.

"Anyway, you said I was going to be doing group training? Should I pack up a bag of my tech to bring along?"

"No, for this exercise, you will only have access to yourselves and what you can find," Ivan replied, turning his attention back to the spreadsheets in front of him. "You'd do best to assume it will be something quite rigorous and mentally prepare yourself. I trust I don't need to tell you to bring your A-game, right? After all, you're representing me as much as yourself, and I have quite the reputation to uphold."

Tori was pretty certain she caught a whisper of a smirk on Ivan's face, but it vanished so quickly she suspected it might have been a trick of the light. There or not, she didn't need visible sarcasm to know that Ivan didn't give two wet shits about his reputation. He probably did, however, know that being Fornax's apprentice would put a target on her back right out of the gate and wanted to make sure she was aware of it going in.

"Nothing to worry about," Tori said. "I'm going to show those other rookies what a real apprentice is made of... which is fire. Real apprentices are made of fire. Wrapped in electronics. With a kicking smile and awesome wit and a sharp—"

"Pleeeeeease stop stalling and go back to work." Ivan looked up from his spreadsheets to glare at her, but only for a second. There was a meeting to prep for, after all.

"You are just no fun at the office. No fun at all." Tori stuck her tongue out at him while his head was down, then opened the door and headed back to her cubicle.

\* \* \*

Apollo floated gently down to the floor, grinning as applause from the trainees reached his ears. Stalwart Iron was already on the ground, having deactivated the thrusters on his legs. Though some of the others felt Stalwart Iron was a bit stiff, Apollo actually found himself fond of the robotic champion. What he lacked in emotion, he made up for in being willing to do grunt work, and that was a trait Apollo always enjoyed in his lackeys.

"That was great, sir." It was one of the trainees. Apollo hadn't bothered to learn most of their names yet, so rather than reply he just gave a smile and a thumbs-up. From behind the rookie, Blunderbuss appeared, massive gun strapped to his back and a pair of would-be criminals unconscious in each arm. Bridge stepped out of the wormhole she'd opened, followed by Battle Cry. A quick motion from Bridge and the warp in space vanished as though it had never been there. Bridge was one of the least well-known capes in the AHC, but she commanded salary and accommodations nearly on par with Apollo's. Utility was almost as important as prestige. Almost.

“Class, please circle around me,” Stalwart Iron commanded. “Apollo has graciously agreed to lead a discussion over the event you all just saw, so we are going to review the footage from multiple angles in order to make sure you’re adequately prepared.”

This bought Apollo time to grab a shower and a sandwich, the former of which was most important. It wouldn’t do to have them noticing the flecks of blood splattered across his bronze skin. It wasn’t even his fault that the bigger goon had been so roughed up. The guy had certainly looked like he could take a punch, after all.

“You sure about leaving the kids with gearhead?” Battle Cry asked as they left the giant hangar designated for landings and entered a much smaller, more intimate hallway. Behind them, Bridge and Blunderbuss dragged the two cuffed and unconscious crooks off to processing, where the police would pick them up for trial after their abilities were adequately sealed off.

“Did you want to lead a half-hour long fight recap?” Apollo asked.

Battle Cry shook her head, sending the straight dark hair of her wig spinning slightly through the air. Underneath her red leather costume and wig, Battle Cry was a normal-looking woman who could and did pass as a regular civilian when at her day job as a local news station’s production assistant. “I just always feel weird about trusting robots. Yeah, he’s nice now, but you never know when one will get uppity and use Xelas’s Law.”

“Stally isn’t going anywhere,” Apollo said. “He’s technically free and loves working for us. Not all of them turn out like Xelas. Besides, do you know literally anyone else in this organization who doesn’t complain when the cleaning staff is off and the toilets need scrubbing?”

“Okay, you make a strong point. Any thoughts on what you’ll tell the trainees?”

“Probably just stick to the usual: assess the situation, use only the necessary amount of force, always go for the capture instead of the kill unless given special authorization. All the shit we’re supposed to teach them. The ones who actually make it through will figure out how things really work pretty quickly.”

“It’s not a bad crop. Some of them could be really strong with enough training. I saw Blunderbuss working with that Ren kid, and man, for a rookie, he could take a beating,” Battle Cry said.

“Regenerative properties are off the charts. Whatever weird cocktail he had in his system didn’t go dormant once the changes were done. It’s still in him, bubbling around and fixing anything we try to break. He’s my frontrunner in the class, for now.”

Battle Cry leaned back, staring at Apollo uncertainly. “What, you think one of those others will pull ahead? I haven’t paid much attention, but it seems unlikely.”

“No, most of them are destined to be second-string,” Apollo replied. “I’m more looking forward to when we see the ones who were smart enough not to get found that first night. Unlike the dipshit brothers we brought in today, there are bound to be a few metas testing and training themselves, exploring their powers on their own. Out of that lot, there are always a couple of standouts. Could be some serious talent, assuming they’re smart enough to join our team instead of bothering with the chump change of robbing a bank.”

“Or before those damned guildies get their hooks in them,” Battle Cry added. “I cannot for the life of me figure out why we don’t just kick their doors down and take them all out once and for all.”

Apollo grinned, an expression that made his face literally light up as his ever-present golden glow intensified. “Can’t very well go attacking them for ostensibly trying to support each other in keeping their noses clean, now can we? They’re too smart to get busted doing any amateur-level shit, so we don’t have cause. And besides, I think it’s useful to have all of them gathered together in a guild like they are.”

“Why on earth is that useful?”

The glow around Apollo grew just a bit brighter, shining off the metal floors of the hall as they walked. “Because when the day for dealing with them finally does arrive, it’s more convenient if they’re all grouped up in the same spot. It’ll make for a much cleaner assault.”



\* \* \*

“Gather round, gather round, the betting is about to open.” Johnny spun the blackboard at his back around, revealing a simple table with the names of all four rookies’ teachers along with a selection of numbers on each person’s name. “Since our wonderful guild members did the service of choosing apprentices this year, you can bet on which one you expect to do the best in this weekend’s special training.”

Johnny Three Dicks stood on a box that was full of protein bars so he could see over the small sea of villains that had gathered to participate in one of their favorite forms of entertainment: betting on each other. The sizable break room, stocked with games and snack machines, was almost filled by the crush of people that had turned out to piss away some of their hard-stolen money. Johnny gleefully spotted a few councilors and felt his greedy heart swell with cheer. If they had turned up, this truly was going to be quite the event.

“For the record, I do not approve of this,” Thuggernaut grunted. He was sitting at a nearby card table, playing a round of hearts with The Bytes. Around them, the other guild members scrambled to see the board better.

“You gave Pseudonym’s girl the best odds?” Wildwood asked, staring at the chalk writing. “No one has even seen what she can do yet.”

“Some of us may have filched a file or two,” Johnny replied, “all in the name of research, of course. But regardless, she’s had several weeks’ head start on the others, so she’s not paying out as much if she wins.”

“I’ll drop a hundred on her,” Xelas said. “She’s got spunk. Let me get fifty on Arachno Bro’s boy as well. You humans do not take well to bugs.”

From the rear of the small crowd, a man in a popped collar with spider mandibles sprouting from his mouth gave a nod, then motioned to Johnny that he wanted to put two hundred on his own apprentice.

“Give me two hundred on Balaam’s guy,” Wildwood said quickly. Several other members of the magical division also placed bets on Balaam’s apprentice. Whether they believed he would actually win or not was

irrelevant. What mattered was making sure Balaam knew they supported him and his endeavors.

Gork called out for three hundred on Pseudonym's apprentice, and others quickly piled in, despite the crappier payout. Stasis broke the mold by betting on Arachno Bro's apprentice. After her, Trilogy was next, and true to his motif, he bet on three of the apprentices, despite the fact that he was functionally guaranteed to lose money no matter who won.

Thuggernaut sat patiently as the bets poured in, villains from all departments of the guild throwing down a few hundred here or there. As he listened, he noticed more and more that his own apprentice was being bet on significantly less than any of the other three. The favor shown for Pseudonym's apprentice was one thing—she did have a head start and a legendary teacher—but the other two weren't anything special. In fact, Thuggernaut considered his own apprentice, Beverly, the strongest of those living at the guild, perhaps even more powerful than Tori. The longer he listened, the more bothered he became by the trend, until finally he laid down his cards and stood forcefully from the table.

The crowd parted before him and he approached the small box that Johnny was standing on. He surveyed the blackboard, taking careful note of each student's odds, then looked his best friend in the eyes.

"I would like to make a bet."

"Seems I recall someone saying this game was 'gauche, barbaric, and uncivilized.' If only I could recall who said those things..." Johnny tapped his fingers together, looking as though he were genuinely plumbing the depths of his mind for the memory.

"That was because it seemed inappropriate to liberate money so easily from a friend. Since you decided to press on, though, I suppose I have no choice." Thuggernaut paused briefly, doing some quick tabulation in his head. "I'd like to bet ten thousand dollars on my own apprentice."

Johnny's whistle carried over the heads of the nearby people who were chattering amongst themselves. Dropping that kind of money was no small feat, and he was her trainer. Maybe he knew something the rest of them didn't.

“Now that is one hell of a bet,” Johnny said. “But per guild rules, I can’t accept anything over five hundred. Pot gets too big and people start getting antsy.”

“Then put me down for five hundred,” Thuggernaut replied. He returned to his card game, only to lose a few moments later. It didn’t particularly bother him, however. In fact, he was showing a slight grin as Gig reshuffled the deck.

From the way people were betting now, it was clear no one was ignoring his apprentice anymore.

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## Chapter 18

It was strange to be approaching the guild's headquarters in a car other than Ivan's. Tori hadn't realized how at home she felt with the silent, brooding man until he was replaced by a robot built to look like a human driver—particularly given that, on the surface, this should have been a fairly good substitute for her teacher.

The experience also left her wondering why on earth Doctor Mechanical hadn't started selling these self-driving robots to the world at large, since it did a marvelous job of taking her through traffic. It was honestly better than most humans she'd ridden with, which meant it would be worthwhile for both the guild's pocketbook and society as a whole. It was possible he didn't release them *because* it would help society, but Doctor Mechanical had never struck Tori as that type of villain.

After disembarking from the car, which she watched drive off and park itself, Tori let herself in to the changing stations that separated the garage from the guild proper. As Ivan promised, one of her Apprentice costumes was waiting there. She slipped out of her work suit and into the comfortable, now-familiar feel of a guild outfit.

She stepped out and was surprised to find someone waiting for her, though she likely shouldn't have been. Xelas wrapped Tori in a powerful hug, squeezing so tightly that it almost triggered Tori's fire-form before letting the softer woman go.

"Are you excited?" Xelas asked, her voice literally buzzing as she spoke. "Getting to meet your fellow rookies, sharing stories and experiences, fighting to the death to see which of you we actually keep?"

"I'm kind of—what the *fuck*?" Tori yelled, her brain catching up to her tongue midway through the reply.

"Calm down, I'm just screwing with you," Xelas said. "Come on, do you really think we'd force you all into a death match for some artificial

reason?”

“Let me meet your question with a question: do you really want me to answer that honestly? Remember, I’ve already got a death threat dangling over my head.”

“Pshhh, we all have those at some point,” Xelas replied. “Honestly, if I don’t have at least three people actively trying to kill me, I feel like I’ve pissed away a week.”

Tori stared at the metal woman for several very long seconds. “Okay, cards on the table: I can’t tell if you’re serious, being glib, or just outright fucking with me.”

“Why pick one when all three seem like great options?” Xelas crooked a finger and motioned down the hall. “Now, come on, your classmates are anxious to meet you.”

Moving slowly but steadily, Tori followed Xelas down the hall. “Are they really? Like, do they know there’s a fourth apprentice?”

“Of course. They’ve got their own teachers, so each one was brought up to speed on the current situation of the guild. They’re also probably all gunning for you, since you’re considered the top seed as Pseudonym’s apprentice.”

“Faaaantastic. Don’t suppose you’d care to even the playing field and tell me a little about them?”

“Technically, since I’m a councilor I’m supposed to be completely neutral, which includes not letting any trainees have advanced information.” As Xelas clipped through the words, it was the first time Tori had ever heard her actually sound robotic, a tone that quickly vanished when she continued. “But screw that, where’s the fun in being a villain if I can’t ignore some rules?”

Xelas and Tori turned down a hallway Tori had never been through before. It was largely bare, save for the usual red trim and a single dark wooden door at the end. Something static seemed to race down Tori’s arm as they drew closer—extra security, maintained by magic, technology, or probably both. At least she knew they were heading in the right direction.

“Thuggernaut’s apprentice is a fellow lady, one who can turn into dragons from what I hear. Balaam has a guy who can do magic by scratching symbols on things, which is weird even for a magic user. And lastly, Arachno Bro is training a kid who can summon swarms of insects. Have lots of fun with that one; just seeing those things makes me glad my skin isn’t soft and vulnerable like you humans.”

“Bleh. I might spend more time in fire-form than I expected,” Tori said. Insects didn’t send her scurrying up the walls, but she still wasn’t a fan. “Any hints as to what we’re going to be doing for training?”

“Sorry, even I know there are lines not to cross. Besides, Doc is way too excited about seeing the surprise on your faces for me to take that away from him.” Xelas reached out and pulled open the door, revealing a staircase that went steeply downward, obscuring whatever lay at the bottom from view. “Here endeth your guided tour. Good luck down there, and remember: don’t start anything, but don’t take people’s crap either. Grudges run deep, as do memories of weakness.”

“Cheery,” Tori muttered. “Thanks, though. When this weekend is done, maybe I can buy you a martini, or whatever your equivalent of booze is. You know, to show my gratitude.”

“Taste sensors are fully equipped, so a martini works fine by me.” Xelas pointed down the staircase with a long metal finger. “Now quit stalling and get down there.”

With a deep breath and a long stare, Tori began her descent. No sooner had she passed the first stair than the door closed firmly behind her. She didn’t need to check to know that it wouldn’t budge if she tried to open it. The message was clear: Tori and the others were being put here. Escape was not an option. At least, probably not yet.

Moving briskly lest anyone at the bottom mistake a slow pace for fear, Tori emerged from the staircase into a spacious room. Multiple large chairs and couches were scattered through it, and at the center was a massive table laden with food and drinks. Tasteful art hung on the walls, and an empty fireplace was set against the far corner. The whole place reminded Tori of a high-end lounge, or at least how she’d pictured them from movies and television.

Three other people were already in the room, each wearing a costume quite similar to her own. One was a broad-shouldered man who was helping himself to a plate of thick sandwiches that rested amid the array of food. Another was a thin, almost sickly guy who was sitting in a chair, eyes darting about the room. The final apprentice was a woman, taller than Tori and leaning against the far wall next to the fireplace.

All eyes turned to her as she stepped off the staircase and into the room. To her surprise, the gazes weren't as unfriendly as she expected. The thin man gave her a courteous nod and the woman kept a neutral expression. Only the one stuffing his face had a non-subdued reaction. He set down his half-eaten meal and strode across the room.

"You must be our fourth apprentice! Damn, nice to meet you, we've all heard nothing but great things." Before Tori could react, he'd swept her hand up in his and was shaking it firmly. "Seeing as we're all technically named 'Apprentice' for now, how about you just go ahead and call me Lance. I don't see any harm in giving you a first name."

"I... um... Tori. My name is Tori." She wasn't sure why she was giving out her name so easily; it was just that Lance's friendliness had taken her off guard. That was not how she had expected to be greeted by her fellow apprentices.

"Tori. Well, that's a lovely name, if I do say so. The fellow over there who needs a sandwich is going by Warren right now, and our silent, strong lady at the far end is Beverly. Seeing as I'm sure someone with your connections already knows who we're apprenticing under, that probably gets you all the way caught up." Lance released her hand and headed back toward the table, where he waved his hand over the food. "We're supposed to eat our fill while we wait for training to start. They seem to think the food is poisoned or something, but I'm five entrees deep and have to say that it must be some damn tasty poison."

"Feel free to ignore him," the lanky lad named Warren told Tori. "We've already begun to."

Tori contemplated ignoring the food like the others, but she didn't really see the point. If they were trying to drug them, there were easier, less obvious ways to go about it. Besides, she'd had a light lunch thanks to Ivan

suddenly dumping a bunch of work on her, and the food did look pretty yummy.

“Screw it; there are worse ways to go.” She walked over and joined Lance, helping herself to some chips and chicken fingers, along with a cold soda. There was also beer in the bucket; however, that seemed to be tempting fate a touch more than she should. No matter what was coming, Tori suspected she was going to need her wits for it.

If Ivan’s training was any indication, whatever was waiting for them would be neither gentle nor easy.

\* \* \*

“Hey, Dad.” Rick gave his father a brief hug before letting go and scurrying in the house. Ivan tried to remind himself that his son was simply at that age where being around any parental figure was, to quote, a drag.

“I missed you, Dad!” Beth jumped up and gave him a big hug, and Ivan took the opportunity to squeeze her tightly. Though she too had entered her teens, Rick’s younger sister hadn’t yet developed the inevitable impending allergy to parental affection. It would be a sad day when they both reached that point, and Ivan intended to get every drop of affection while he still could.

“I missed you, too,” Ivan said, finally setting his daughter down and ushering her inside. From the Jeep in the driveway, Janet gave a solemn nod to her ex-husband, which Ivan returned. Avoiding each other made keeping up a peaceful appearance much easier, especially given how much they couldn’t talk about in front of the kids.

Shutting the door firmly behind him, Ivan turned to find Rick sprawled out on the couch with the television already turned on, while Beth sat in a nearby chair. “I’m so sorry I had to reschedule our last visit. Did you all have fun at the theme park at least?”

“Heck yeah, we went on a ton of rides,” Beth said.

“But we missed the freaking event of the year in town,” Rick grumbled from his slouched position on the couch. “All everyone at school is talking about is that weird storm. They say a bunch of people even got



superpowers from the lightning. Maybe if we'd stayed, we could have been able to fly or something."

"Or maybe you'd have been turned into a fly-like monster with a proboscis for a face and tattered wings for arms," Ivan countered. "These accidents are very dangerous things. Not every meta is happy about what they are, you know."

"Progress comes with a price." Rick clicked through the channels until he came upon a documentary about NASA's newest probe being sent off in the direction of the last alien debris that had rained down on Earth.

"I'm set with a regular face and arms," Beth replied. "Roller coasters beat weird chemical storms any day of the week."

"And that's why she's the smart one," Ivan said. Despite his teasing tone, he actually meant it. Rick might have a knack with mathematics, but Beth was the only one of the two who seemed to realize that metas and aliens and subterranean species weren't always good things. More than one person with a relentless interest in metas had found their way to join the inhuman ranks, often with terrible results. Had Ivan possessed the power, he would have shielded his children against anything that might steal their humanity. Sadly, that was beyond even his exceptional abilities.

"Off the couch and go get ready for dinner," Ivan commanded. "I've made a big enough meal that even the two of you should get full, but only washed hands get to eat."

Beth took off quickly with Rick moving at a weary trudge. Ivan watched them go then turned his attention to the remaining work in the kitchen. He glanced at the table and noticed he'd forgotten to set a place. He quickly realized that no, he'd been right the first time. For a moment he'd forgotten that Tori wasn't in the house with them and therefore wouldn't be joining the family for dinner. It was a relief not to have to worry about her tinkering away in the basement, perhaps courting an explosion to blow up his house's foundation. But, if he were completely honest, it was also a bit strange not to have her raiding his fridge and peppering him with questions he didn't want to answer.

Ivan shook off the sentiment and continued into the kitchen. There was no point in worrying about his apprentice. She was in capable hands that would give better training than he could ever hope to. Assuming said training, or the other apprentices, didn't find a way to kill her, of course.

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Tori was on her third bag of chips when they heard the thumping of steps coming down the staircase. As soon as the figure stepped into view, it was instantly recognizable to her and she suspected to the others as well. Doctor Mechanial stood before them in all his metal-suited glory, spiked glowing helmet fixed firmly over his face. This was not the councilor or instructor she had met previously: this was the leader of their guild and the overseer of their future.

“You all have been chosen for the chance to join our organization. This is a burden we will place on you, a trust you must guard carefully, and a privilege few will ever see. Our lives are not easy, nor do we have the luxury of being soft people. Therefore, over the next few days, I will test the strength of your bodies, powers, and minds. If you can endure this hardship, you will be one step closer to true membership, and all that comes with it.”

From behind Doctor Mechanial, Tunnel Vision stepped into view, separating to flank their leader. The sister, who Tori suspected was Vision but had yet to confirm, stiffened as her eyes began to glow. Her twin brother, the most likely candidate for Tunnel, raised his hands and pressed them to a nearby wall. Before their eyes, the red-painted plaster disintegrated, revealing a long stretch of plains similar to the one Ivan had taken Tori to the weekend prior. Gasps came from Lance and Beverly, though Warren seemed oddly unfazed. Tori wondered if he'd already seen this trick before. Hell, for all she knew, he could do it himself; it wasn't as though anyone had been forthcoming about their powers so far.

“All of you, step through.” Doctor Mechanial pointed to the open gateway to clarify, as though there were another place they could go. Tori bit down a sarcastic comment and followed orders, moving from the cool, air-conditioned room to a hot, arid landscape. By her guess, they were probably in the same general area where she and Ivan had trained, though

this spot had mesas looming over them, partially blocking out the cloudless sky.

Lance, Warren, and Beverly followed suit, all three squinting as their eyes adjusted to the bright sun now glaring down on them. Doctor Mechaniacal followed, stepping out of the side of the cliff where the portal had manifested. Tori still wondered how they knew where to set the connecting spots up when they made these tunnels through space, though she had a theory that involved telepathy and far-sight.

“Your test for the following days is a simple one,” Doctor Mechaniacal informed them. “Scattered throughout this area are an array of robots designed to attack you on sight. Additionally, there are hidden caches containing food, supplies, and other useful items. Your primary goal is to survive. Anyone who is so injured that they require intervention is deemed a failure. On top of that, however, there is a secondary goal. Every robot has a metallic core inside of them, ones made of copper, silver, gold, and platinum. The more valuable the metal, the more difficult the robot holding it will be to kill. Those who survive and bring back those cores will be paid for what they collected. Copper wins you ten dollars, silver a hundred, gold a thousand, and one of the rare, precious platinum cores is worth ten thousand dollars. Additionally, whoever gets the most money is deemed the winner and receives one hundred and fifty percent of their orbs’ value.”

Tori’s eyes went wide. She could practically feel the excitement humming in her fellow trainees. That was a *shitload* of money up for grabs, all for the simple task of beating up robots. Then again, these were robots designed by Doctor Mechaniacal, so she’d be a fool to assume they’d go down easily. But damn... ten thousand dollars would buy a lot of high-end tech, and no doubt the others had their own uses for such large sums of money. For training villains, cash in hand was the perfect motivation.

“At sunset on Sunday, you will be here, waiting for us to bring you back. Failure to do so is just that: failure. Your test begins now,” Doctor Mechaniacal informed them, stepping back through the portal into the cool, safe room they had all walked away from. Seconds later, the window across space was gone, leaving them all staring at the plain, craggy side of a brown cliff.

A smile crested Tori's face as she surveyed the landscape, wondering where those wonderful robots bent on her destruction might be hiding. The real training had officially begun.

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## Chapter 19

Warren hunched over and began to scrawl symbols on the dusty ground. Before Tori's eyes, each one glowed as his finger traced the strange, arcane shapes into existence. When they were completed, each flashed with an emerald light before causing different effects. The first rune sent a wave of energy rippling out, washing over the four apprentices and continuing off in all directions. Warren's second rune solidified the dirt around it, transforming it into a green stone that he plucked from the ground and stuck in his pocket. The third and final rune conjured a green fire before burning out, leaving an arrow pointing toward one of the nearby cliffs.

"That should buy us a little time," Warren informed them. "My blast will scramble just about any manner of detection software the robots are using. You have perhaps an hour, at best, so I suggest everyone find a safe place where they can hole up and wait this out."

"With orbs worth ten grand out there? No way I'm ducking down." Lance reached out and a small swarm of flies materialized in front of his palm. The swarm grew exponentially, doubling in size every few seconds, until the sound of tiny flapping wings filled the air and set Tori's teeth on edge. At last, Lance made a small gesture and his myriad of miniature minions took to the air, scattering in every direction as they buzzed through the dry desert air.

"And what exactly did that accomplish?" Warren asked.

"I'll tell you if you explain the rock and the arrow," Lance replied.

"Neat as both tricks were, don't any of you think that maybe we should talk strategy?" Tori suggested. "Seems like there's a lot of money at stake; might make sense to come up with some sort of coherent plan."

The other three turned to stare at her with expressions that made Tori wonder if she'd somehow insulted their mothers, lovers, and honor all at once with her proposal. It was Beverly who finally spoke, voicing the sentiment that the others were clearly feeling.

“What strategy do we need to talk about? Everyone goes out, kills all the robots they can, and reaps what they earned. Or do you think you deserve a cut of everyone’s winnings just because your teacher is on the council?”

“The fuck?” Tori jerked a thumb at Warren, who did his best to look inconspicuous. “His teacher, Balaam, is on the council too, not that it matters in the first place. I wasn’t trying to take control or demand a cut, just pointing out that it might make more sense to work together, or at least coordinate. Think about it: four tiers of robot, four of us. Doesn’t it seem like maybe we’re only going to be able to take down the tougher ones working as a team?”

“Perhaps your teacher has placed you under some serious misconceptions,” Warren said. “We are all training under a guild of *villains*, people who personify the self-reliant ideology. While some collaboration is necessary for the guild’s survival, it is certainly not meant to be the focus of our training. Look at the challenge itself: those who take the risks reap the rewards. All of it was built around the idea of us getting our own winnings.”

Warren, it seemed, either already had Balaam’s unwillingness for teamwork or had been taught it in their short time together. It wasn’t exactly a surprise to Tori; she’d hoped for better, but had expected the worst. What she hadn’t expected was Beverly and Lance to nod along with the sickly-thin young man, clearly on the same page. They were wrong, though; Tori had seen firsthand how much focus the guild placed on working together. The council meeting, the groups of friends, the code—all of it indicated that guild members were never entirely on their own, for better or worse.

“Look, I think you aren’t really seeing everything about this challenge. If we coordinate with one another—”

“So sorry that we foolish newcomers don’t have your depth of perspective,” Warren interrupted. “But I think it’s you who is missing something: no one cares what you think. We all know this is a competition, and we won’t let you trick us into wasting our time so you can pull ahead. Keep chattering if you like; I for one am done listening.”

With that, Warren jogged away from the rest of the group and toward the direction his arrow had pointed him in. Lance looked at Tori and gave a half-apologetic shrug before heading off at a brisk pace in another direction. For a moment, only Tori and Beverly remained.

“I get what you were trying to do,” Beverly said carefully. “Thuggernaut told me you probably wouldn’t be as bad as the rumors made you out to be, and it seems like you really were thinking of what was best for everyone. That said, I can’t work with anyone else. It’s too dangerous for all of you.”

Tori watched as Beverly headed north. Her stomach sank as she realized how blinded the three of them were by their fears, ambitions, and inherited prejudices. In a way, the schism among them was her fault; these three weren’t just new to the guild, they were new to being meta-humans. To them, this was as much about testing their new abilities as it was racking up the cash, and she’d just stepped all over their egos by suggesting they’d need help before she even saw what they could do. Tori still didn’t think she was wrong in how they should have approached the trial, but it was clear there were more diplomatic methods she could have utilized.

With little other choice, she headed off in the direction no one else had, which she estimated to be south based on the sun’s position overhead. Night would be coming within the next few hours, so she’d need a place to hole up and maybe some supplies to tide her over. Tori’s form flickered as her flesh turned to flames, and soon she was racing across the landscape. Fire-form was faster and weighed less, not to mention kept her less vulnerable, so for the moment, it was her best option to explore with. Once night fell and she’d stick out like a burning beacon, Tori would have to switch to other tactics.

She just hoped she’d come up with some by the time the sun dipped below the horizon.

\* \* \*

“Not the strongest of starts,” Johnny noted. He, Thuggernaut, Xelas, and Gork were holed up in Xelas’s quarters, watching the apprentices scatter to the four points of the compass toward dangerous robotic adversaries. Xelas had a screen that comprised an entire wall of her living

room, one that could show a single picture or multiple feeds, making it the perfect place to monitor the various cameras showing the rookies as they trudged through the desert.

“I thought Thuggernaut’s girl was going to get wise and join up for a minute there,” Xelas said. “Would have given those two a big damn advantage right off the bat.”

“Sadly, Beverly is not yet confident in either her control or in another’s ability to withstand her power,” Thuggernaut said. “Against Tori, I doubt she could do much, but until she gains confidence, she’ll keep separating herself and trying to work alone.”

“She will get there in time, as we all did.” Gork patted Thuggernaut with a wide, stony hand, and smiled at him in a way that made people run in terror. He knew the showing of all her teeth was meant as a sign of empathy, however, and returned her kindness with a grin of his own.

“She has a strong heart and a good mind. Nearly trampling her family on the night she changed left a deep scar, but I believe she can work past it as her experience grows. Truthfully, I’m hopeful that losing to some of Doctor Mechanical’s creations will show Beverly that her power does have limits.”

“Personally, I’m hoping at least two of them get knocked out,” Johnny said. “Almost no one bet on complete drops, which means I’ll make a tidy sum if they go down.”

“You are all heart,” Xelas said.

“So says the Tin Woman. Can you really blame me for looking on the bright side, though? As it stands, those kids might make it through some coppers, perhaps even a silver or two, but the minute the golds come into play, they’re all toast. At least in my perspective, someone is making a little money off of it.”

“Don’t count your coins yet, Johnny,” Gork cautioned. “This is an interesting crop. I would be careful about assuming any outcomes until they actually happen.”



Johnny reached over to the table and grabbed a handful of popcorn from a bowl. “Look, no one is hoping for a turnaround more than me. The better a show they put on, the more bets I’ll get for the next event. I hope they all make it to the end, or at least go down fighting a platinum core.”

Xelas let out a trilling, unpleasant sound. “A platinum? We want them to learn, not die.”

With a shrug, Johnny downed his fistful of popcorn in a single bite. “Guess they’d better learn quick, then.”

\* \* \*

A high-pitched whine filled the air as Tori’s flames melted the hovering robot’s rear rotors and singed its already-exposed circuitry. It managed to squeeze off a few more bolts of concentrated electricity, spraying the rocks to Tori’s north with small, crackling white blasts before it finally gave out and crashed to the ground.

For good measure, Tori blasted the thing with a torrent of flame until it was little more than a melted hunk of scrap. Only then did she walk over and dig into the exposed shell, working her fingers around until she produced a small orb roughly twice the size of a marble.

“More copper.” She hadn’t expected anything different—after all, this was the third of the drones Tori had taken down, and the other two had also carried copper cores in them. As far as opponents went, they were quick and annoying, but not much of a threat to someone who could render themselves functionally intangible. There was some amount of danger—the electricity made her feel weird when it shot through her, and she assumed enough of it would cause serious problems—but overall, she could easily survive the weekend if all she had to do was pick off copper enemies.

Moving carefully, Tori headed back into the small alcove she’d found along a cliff’s edge. It wasn’t great cover, but it did come with the oh-so-homey touch of having a cache of supplies hidden inside. It had contained meal replacement bars and bottles of water, which Tori recognized for the treasures they were immediately. There was also a scroll sealed with some strange symbol she couldn’t recognize. After carefully trying to break the wax and open it, Tori decided to let the scroll be when it

resisted. Ivan hadn't taught her much about magic, but one of his key lessons was not to mess with it unless she knew what she was doing. Given the context clues around the scroll, it was an aid clearly not meant for her, so she left it in the bottom of the metal box that held her discovered supplies.

With the patrolling robot gone, she turned her attention to the project it had stolen her away from: digging through the weak spots in the sand to deepen her alcove. One thing living as a criminal had imparted to Tori was the importance of having a home base. She would need somewhere to stash her supplies, to hide out if things got bad, and to recover if she became injured. It would take a lot of effort, but she estimated it would be possible to build up enough dirt to cover her entrance and get some much needed rest. There were two more days of this to go, and Tori assumed the first afternoon had only been a warm-up.

Idly, she wondered how the others were doing. Warren was probably set; the versatility of his power almost certainly lent itself to creating a shelter. She wasn't sure he'd fare as well on offense; though, without seeing all he could do, there was no way to tell. Lance was a toss-up, as she wasn't exactly sure how his power worked. With enough insects, Tori supposed he might surround himself in a giant swarm that could serve as a shield. Beverly was the one that Tori most worried about. That dragon-form of hers might be tough enough to fight Thuggernaut and therefore resilient enough to shrug off tiny blasts from the copper drone bots, but there was no way it would lend itself to a restful night of sleep.

"Idiots should have listened to me," Tori grumbled as her hands tore deeper into the sandy dirt pressed against the cliff. "Warren could have given us shelter, Lance's bugs could have been an early warning system, and then Beverly and I could have handled anything that broke through." It was an optimistic dream, both in terms of what people could do and in assessing their willingness to work together. Still, it was a nice image to cling to as her hands shoveled the dirt.

Deep down, Tori knew that her worries were also based in fear. What if she was the only one having any trouble with this stuff? What if each of the others had torn apart heaps of robots and built a shelter from their scraps? She pictured them sitting on thrones of hidden caches. The

realist in her knew this was unlikely, but without a firm grasp of what each of them could do, it was impossible to rule anything out. Tori might not have cared about being the only apprentice in the guild or even the expectations set on her because Ivan was her teacher. What she did care about was the idea of losing, of slipping into last place, of failing.

The dirt around her wavered. For an instant she was back in that hospital room, the endless beeping of the monitors like a drill boring through her skull. Both of them were lying there, staring at her with what little willpower over their bodies they still possessed. Then the vision was gone, and Tori realized she'd accidentally heated up her alcove by twenty degrees.

She stepped out into the air. The evening was a cool contrast from the now scorching hideout, even if it did put her at higher risk of being seen by a patrolling bot. She could use a break from being alone with her thoughts, and violence didn't seem like such a bad way to clear her head. Besides, sooner or later she would have to go on the offensive. The world was a hard place; Tori Rivas knew she had to rise through it by her own force of will. She'd learned that lesson long before she was assigned to learn under Ivan.

Her eyes wandered to the starry sky, a gorgeous tapestry of twinkling lights perfectly visible through the clear air. No city lights to obscure the view. Tori enjoyed the stars; not as much as when she was a child, but they still filled her with a sense of wonder to look up at them and sense her small place in the cosmos.

Small for the moment, anyway. Tori was nothing if not ambitious. She turned away from the comfort of the night sky and plunged back into the alcove, determined to fortify her defense as quickly as possible. Once her home base was secure, she could turn her attention to the next step in her plan.

Come sunrise, Tori was going hunting.

## Chapter 20

Ivan tapped his finger against the center of the mouse, not hard enough to click anything, just loud enough to cause an annoying rattle of plastic. He was on his laptop in the kitchen while his children still slumbered upstairs. If Wade ever found a way to convert teenage sleeping abilities into an energy source, he'd be able to power North America for centuries with just this generation. Glancing at the clock, Ivan decided to give them another half hour before forcibly dragging them into consciousness.

The news items on his feed scrolled by, headlines that Ivan looked at without seeing. His own sleep the prior night had been restless, and as the morning sun streamed through his blinds, there was no denying the cause: Tori. He was worried about his apprentice. Guild training wasn't often intentionally deadly, but accidents had been known to happen. Wade liked to test people thoroughly, to see how they reacted in the most pressure-filled situations. True, it was a good way to see how well people kept their heads when the world was burning down around them, but it carried the sincere risk of them being caught up in the flames.

Shutting his laptop firmly, Ivan got up from the table and went to his fridge to pull out some eggs and bacon. Cooking would take his mind off Tori and would hopefully help wake up his children. It wasn't as though he needed to worry about her, really. Tori was smart, strong, and had a solid ability, even if it was one she seemed dead set on letting stagnate. Pride aside, so long as she used her head, she could avoid whatever big threats Wade had put into play. Assuming she didn't get stubborn and try to pull out a win for no reason, of course.

The pan sizzled as Ivan dropped the first few eggs into its burning embrace. He was trying to make himself not worry about Tori by working from the assumption that she wouldn't act prideful or stubborn... this was, to put it mildly, completely ridiculous.

Turning the day's schedule over in his head, Ivan remembered that Beth was going to the pool with her friend. Rick would certainly end up walking aimlessly around the mall. There might be time to slip over to the base and check on his apprentice. Just the thought made Ivan's tension ease. He would pop over, reassure himself that his apprentice was fine, and then enjoy the rest of his weekend unconcerned.

Mind made up, Ivan pulled the bacon from its package and laid it carefully in a pan before sending it to roast in the oven.

\* \* \*

Tori was thankful she had heat-based powers as the morning sun bore down on her. The others were probably sweltering by this point, unless they had an ability to block out the endless rays. An image of Lance with a cloud of flies acting as a living umbrella popped into Tori's head and she choked back a snort. The copper cores in her pocket were already making enough noise as it was; she didn't need to draw any more robots before she was ready.

Her morning's hunt had gone well, netting four more cores to add to her collection. She'd been keeping them on her person, which was a pain given how they would fall away during her phase shifts, but she wasn't quite ready to drop off her winnings at the alcove she'd renovated into a near-proper cave. After dispatching so many copper-cored robots, Tori's confidence was beginning to grow. She wasn't certain she was ready to take on a silver yet, but she'd like to at least find one. Research was as much a part of hunting as actual engagement.

A loud explosion from one of the nearby mesas sent Tori spinning into a crouch, a fireball conjured in each hand as she readied for attack. When none immediately came, her posture relaxed. She stared in the direction of the explosion, near the top of the mesa. Someone else must be fighting, and she'd never heard one of the copper-cored drones make a noise like that. Tori surveyed her surroundings quickly, wondering if there was a way she might be able to scale the cliff face quickly enough to catch the show. It was only about thirty feet high, but she wasn't exactly a practiced climber.

Before she could figure out if it was worth the risk, a big, scaly green figure came into view near the mesa's edge. It didn't look like any dragon Tori had ever seen, but by process of elimination, that was all it could be. The thing certainly seemed built for damage: sharp claws, powerful limbs, and a hide armored with hundreds of scales. Tori found herself thankful she didn't actually have to fight Beverly to win the contest.

As quickly as the thought entered her brain, Tori saw the dragon jerked backward—flung through the air, in fact—toward the center of the mesa, out of Tori's line of sight. Even without the somehow panicked expression on Beverly's now snout-wearing face, Tori could have put the clues together.

Her fellow apprentice was getting her green ass kicked. Badly, from the sounds of the scuffle that reached Tori's ears. It was very, very tempting to turn around and pretend she hadn't seen anything out of sorts, but Tori immediately dismissed the idea. Aside from the facts—that Beverly had almost definitely seen her and that almost every guild member she'd met had warned her to avoid grudges—Tori just honestly didn't want to leave the woman in harm's way. This place was dangerous, and it just as easily could be her in over her head if she went the wrong way. She'd tried telling them there was merit in working together; now it was time to try showing.

All of which was a good thought, but as Tori pulled out her copper cores and stashed them under a nearby rock, she realized her initial hurdle had yet to be dealt with: how the hell was she going to get up the cliff in time? She could practically hear Ivan's voice, telling her over and over again that exploring her power would pay endless dividends when she found herself in tough situations.

"Come on, there's a way up there," she muttered, staring at the sheer rock face as her physical eyes vanished in a burning wave that cascaded across her body. In fire-form, she had less mass, so it was possible she could take the cliff in a series of jumps. The trouble was that she also lost almost all the strength she'd need to launch herself. Aside from burning and rolling across, Tori had limited capacity to interact with physical objects. Ivan would have told her to find a new way to go at the problem, just as he'd told her to try new tactics when attacking him. He wasn't even here

and he was nagging her, which made it all the worse. Tori would have blasted his face with a fire beam if he'd actually shown up at that moment.

In fire-form, Tori could not blink, but she gave it her best shot as a rogue idea entered her head. It would be risky, no question about that, and her control would be imprecise at best. Still, there was no reason it couldn't work, as long as she kept her focus. Besides, at this point a maybe was better than nothing.

Leaning forward, Tori pointed both of her arms toward the ground and began to blast the sand with twin streams of steady fire. As the dirt heated up below her, Tori focused on tightening the streams, increasing the heat while decreasing the surface area of each beam. They grew smaller and fiercer until at last Tori felt her flame feet lift up slowly from the ground. Tilting her arms slightly, she angled her rise so that it put her on course with the looming cliff where the sounds of battle still filled the air.

It wasn't the fastest way to fly, but Tori still felt exhilarated as she rose higher into the air. Before, her concern had been with keeping a low profile, not letting people know what she could do. Never in her life would she have imagined soaring through Ridge City, let alone actually tried it. Yet now she was lifting off the ground, moving through the sky on no power but her own. It was thrilling, scary, and firmly confirmed what Tori had hitherto been wavering on: her meta-suit would definitely have flight capabilities.

As she crested the top of the mesa, Tori finally saw the conflict she'd been listening to for the last several minutes. Beverly was lumbering about, moving as fast as her sizable body would allow while a giant silver orb on four thick legs tracked her every step. Metal tendrils snaked out from its right side, whipping at her thick hide and trying to wind themselves around her limbs. Beverly leapt back, clawing and snapping as they came near, then tried to turn the tables by charging her attacker. The orb's left side opened up, a whole section swiveling freely, connected by a single large arm. Though Tori couldn't see exactly what happened, she did notice the air between Beverly and the robot ripple for the span of several seconds. Beverly crashed to the ground, aborting her charge and letting out a roar of pain. She backpedaled quickly as the metal tendrils tried to capitalize on her injury.

“Fuck me,” she muttered. “Sonic attacks on one side, big metal whips on the other.” It was a good system, perfect in both a melee or ranged context while also dealing with problematic people like Tori. She wasn’t sure how a concentrated blast of sound would affect her fire-form, but she had a hunch it wouldn’t be pleasant. On the other hand, judging by the gashes Beverly left in the robot’s tendrils when they came near enough to strike, she’d probably tear it apart if she could get close enough.

All of it added up to one inescapable and very depressing conclusion: Tori would have to be the distraction if they were actually going to drop this damn thing. It sucked like hell, but she still tilted her arms slightly left, circling around to land behind the metal bastard. If she was going to do this, she was going to make damn sure it would be effective. As long as she could make it turn its back on Beverly, the dragon apprentice could hopefully do the rest.

It occurred to Tori as she landed carefully on the mesa’s flat surface that she was leaving an awful lot of her rescue mission to maybes and ifs. By that point, though, she was already committed, so she pushed the thought from her mind as a massive fireball built in her hand.

“Beverly! When this thing comes at me, don’t you dare fucking hesitate. If I get killed from this, I am going to haunt the living shit out of you!”

A slight roar over the whirl of robotic limbs was the only response, which Tori decided to take as a signal of understanding. It wasn’t like she had a lot of choices left, anyway. Taking careful aim at the rear of the metal orb on legs, Tori let loose a torrent of flame, blasting its body with a column of fire as thick as a baseball bat.

To her surprise, the orb didn’t rotate around to face her. Instead, panels near the areas she was pelting with heat opened up, glassy camera lenses fixed on Tori as she poured as much energy as she could into the attack. They watched her as she dug in, but from the sounds of scuffle coming from the robot’s other side, it seemed she wasn’t making enough of an impression to split its focus.

“All right, you big testicle. Come get some.” Tori concentrated the beam in front of her, tightening it just as she had the ones that lifted her



off the ground. In principle, it was the same technique she used for small-scale soldering and welding, though she'd never tried it on something this big before. As the beam shrank down, Tori could see sparks beginning to fly from the spot where her beam connected to the robot's body. It wasn't much, but it gave her the encouragement to keep going, narrowing her blast further until a cascade of sparks shot out of the robot's weakening body.

Tori knew she'd succeeded when she saw the sonic cannon flip around and point at her. She dimly made out the sound of charging footsteps before her entire body seemed to explode in a wave of pain. Her focus was shot and the beam dissipated as Tori struggled to hold her body together. The endless, pulsing waves ripped through her, trying to scatter the sentient flames that made up her consciousness. Tori couldn't see or hear or think; all she could do was hold herself together by sheer force of will.

Then it was over, agony replaced by a loud crunching sound barely audible through the ringing in her ears. Tori slowly realized that she did indeed have ears again, and that her hands were pressed over them. Pulling her palms away from her head, Tori could see streaks of blood smeared from her thumbs to her wrists. That sonic cannon had seriously not been screwing around.

Moving carefully, Tori pulled herself up from the ground where it turned out she'd been kneeling, her head hammering in pain with every inch she progressed. As Tori reached a fully standing position, the world around her spun violently and she lost her footing. She fell backward, waiting to feel the sting of impact against the mesa's hard surface, only to instead be greeted by wind whistling through her ears.

Right... she'd stood on the edge of the mesa. It had seemed like a good idea at the time, allowing her to slip over the lip if she needed to dodge. Plummeling through the air, however, Tori recognized that it might have been a strategic mistake. She closed her eyes and tried to shift back to her fire-form, but for the first time she could ever recall, her body rebelled.

Tori glanced upward, back to where she had fallen from, and was shocked to see another form closing in fast on her. She let out a small yelp as it snagged her in a pair of powerful claws. Then, at long last, the part she'd been expecting arrived.

Her fall, as all falls do, came to a sudden and abrupt stop.

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## Chapter 21

Tori rejoined the world of the living slowly, with pain being the first and most persistent thing to greet her. The sun stung her eyes, the ringing in her ears had yet to fade, and her arms felt like they'd nearly been pulled out of their sockets. She wasn't dead, though, and considering how things had been going when she blacked out, that was an unexpected improvement. Moving slowly lest another bout of unconsciousness take hold, Tori raised herself to a sitting position and took stock of the world around her.

She was lying on top of the mesa where they'd done battle, a fact made obvious by the sparking and smoking husk of a robot resting twenty feet away. From the position of the sun in the sky, she guessed she'd only been out for a couple of minutes, though it certainly felt like a lot longer. To her surprise, Beverly was still there, though no longer wearing the form of the hulking green dragon nor of the creature that had snatched her out of the sky. Tori's fellow apprentice had shed her mask and seemed to be taking in the sunshine. Without the obstruction, it was clear that Beverly was quite beautiful. Well-crafted cheekbones, skin like light cocoa powder, and piercing green eyes all made her quite captivating, and that was without even taking the dragon-powers into account.

"I didn't know you had a form that could fly," Tori said, snapping Beverly out of her restful daze. She scrambled up quickly, watching Tori carefully to see if a fireball was impending.

"Why did you help me?" Beverly took two steps back, and her eyes seemed to glow slightly. Their natural green tint darkened and the tips of her nails seemed to elongate by several inches.

"Whoa, shit, chill." Tori raised both of her hands upward in a sign of surrender. "I didn't really have some sort of grand plan going in. It just looked like you needed help, and I hadn't gotten the chance to see what one of the big bots could do... which, by the way, please tell me that bastard was at least a gold-cored."

Beverly shook her head slowly, reaching into her pocket to produce a gleaming metal ball. “Silver, if you can believe it. These things are on a pretty steep difficulty curve.”

“Shitballs. I’m not sure I even want to see a gold if that thing was a silver.” Tori had been expecting the higher value models to be tougher, but that thing had nearly taken down the both of them. Then again, it wasn’t as though they’d used a coordinated attack or strategy. With a little planning, she and Beverly could probably bring one down without too much risk. Going at it solo, however, would be pretty much impossible without her tech.

Fluctuations in the ringing sound filling her ears alerted Tori to the fact that Beverly was talking, though the words were impossible to make out since she’d lowered her voice.

“Huh? Sorry, damn bot did a number on my ears. You have to speak up.”

“I said THANK YOU!” Beverly yelled, a touch of red tingeing her cheeks as she shouted to repeat herself. “For helping me take that thing down. I wasn’t sure how I was going to deal with it.”

“Seeing as you saved me from doing a swan dive into the ground, I think we can call it even.” Tori lowered her arms slowly, making sure Beverly wouldn’t think she was about to attack. “Look, I’m in a fair amount of pain here, so I’d like to switch to my fire-form to heal. I don’t want you thinking I’m about to do something stupid, though, thus I am formally giving you warning that I’m about to turn into living flame.”

Beverly hesitated for a moment and then nodded. Tori focused on shifting to her other form; waves of relief filled her as her body complied. Part of her was reassured to know the sonic cannon hadn’t done any serious damage or blocked her power, but the vast majority of her brain was overwhelmed by happiness as the pain shrank to a dull ache. It would take an hour or so for her body to completely regenerate away her injuries; in the meantime, she’d feel a lot less pain without actual nerve receptors to send the signals.

“Hot damn, that is a neat trick,” Beverly said. “And yes, pun very much intended.”

“Coming from a gal I watched go from ripping up a robot to soaring through the skies, that’s quite a compliment.” Tori scanned the area around them as they talked; it wouldn’t do to have their conversation broken up by more attackers.

“Yeah, actually didn’t know I could do that.” Beverly slowed lowered herself to the ground, picking up her mask and slipping it over her face. “My powers didn’t come with much in the way of instructions. Just found an old amulet in our attic and then poof, suddenly I’m gigantic and tearing apart the house.”

“Coolest thing I ever found in my family’s attic as a kid was an old mannequin head,” Tori said. “My parents told me it belonged to my grandpa, but now that I think about it, he worked at a meat processing plant, why the hell would he own... actually, I don’t think I want to see where that train of thought ultimately leads.”

“I’d say that’s a smart call,” Beverly said. “My great-grandmother used to collect weird artifacts and charms. Most of it was supposed to be junk, but I guess she found a few pieces of the genuine article.”

“Or it used to be junk and turned into a genuine article,” Tori pointed out. “No one really knows where all these magic talismans keep popping up from. We’re pretty sure magic used to not be real, though.”

“Well, it damn sure is now. I’m the living, sometimes fire-breathing proof of that. Just wish I at least knew what all I could do. Flying would have made getting up here the first time a hell of a lot easier.”

Tori could relate, now that she’d tasted a bit of air mobility herself. “So you flew just because you were trying to save me?”

“Thuggernaut thinks my intuition is to access the power reactively. First time, I was scared and in pain, so I turned into a big green dragon that’s made to give and take punishment. Second time, they were making me fight a bunch of targets that kept pinning me and then fading back, which pissed me off. I got so mad I ended up turning into my red dragon-

form and blasting them with fire breath. This time, I didn't want your death on my conscience, and lo and behold, I sprout some wings for arms. Pretty sure that form had white scales, though I don't always get the cleanest view."

"Definitely white," Tori confirmed. "I can remember it perfectly. Honestly, I doubt I'll ever get the image of you barreling down toward me out of my head. Which, um, thanks, by the way."

Beverly waved her hand through the air. "Like you said, we're even. And if I happen upon you getting owned by one of those things, count on me to jump in. Competition or not, I can do at least that much."

"What if neither of us had to get owned by another robot?" Tori had been biding her time, hoping to build slowly to the topic, but from the way Beverly had started to rise, it was clear she had to take her shot or lose the opportunity. "What if we worked together, this time from the start? With a little planning, the two of us could tear those things apart."

"Look, I was in the fight too. I know it would be easier if we teamed up. But I'm still learning to control these powers of mine. What if next time I'm the one who accidentally injures you?"

"Claws, fire, and wings aren't going to hurt me, at least not easily," Tori said. "Unless you're keeping a hidden form in your arsenal—which is not me prying, if you are—then you don't have to worry about doing anything worse than the robots can do. I'm a lot tougher than I look." To prove her point, Tori flowed upward from the ground, expanding to add a bit of presence to her fiery visage.

"And you look pretty tough as is." Beverly sighed and shook her head. "Even aside from putting you in danger, doesn't working together defeat the entire point of this exercise? We're clearly pitted against each other. Teaming up probably breaks the rules."

"Doctor Mechanical never said anything about us not being allowed to help each other or splitting our winnings. Sure, this contest implies that we're supposed to be on our own, but short of anything being stated outright, it's a gray area at best. Besides all of that, though, you're overlooking the most important reason why it doesn't matter."

Beverly pursed her lips as she stared at this strange fire-woman and the increasingly convincing madness she was spitting out. “And what exactly is that?”

“We’re training to be villains. Half the fun of that is ignoring the rules when it suits us. And right now, I’d say it suits both our interests quite well.”

\* \* \*

Ivan was unsurprised by the festive atmosphere in Xelas’s room when he arrived; that everyone seemed relatively sober and no argument had broken out was by far the bigger miracle. He’d have much preferred to check things out with Wade; however, Doctor Mechaniacal’s full attention was rightfully on the trial he was coordinating. Since Ivan had refused anything more than a bare-bones quarters where he could rest if needed, that made sitting in with Xelas and company his next best option to assuage his worries about his apprentice. Not that he would admit that’s what he was doing, of course. Ivan was merely looking in to evaluate her performance, as any good teacher would.

“And here he is, coming in halfway through the second day,” Johnny cried as soon as Ivan stepped into view. “Who had Saturday afternoon?”

Gork raised one of her massive, thick-fingered hands. “Had a hunch.”

“All right, everyone, that’s a hundred apiece, since Gork won the pool.” Johnny pulled a crisp bill from his pocket. Thuggernaut took his from a small pouch at his side and Xelas seemed to have one dispense from her wrist. All three slapped the money down in front of Gork, who quietly collected her winnings and squirreled them away.

“If everyone is quite finished having their fun, perhaps one of you could catch me up on how things are going.” Ivan glanced down at the modest watch adorning his wrist, a timepiece that cost less than Gork had won only moments before. “I do have a daughter to pick up in an hour.”

“Calm down, spoilsport,” Xelas chided. She motioned for Ivan to come over and have a seat. As he did, she pointed to the many screens displayed before them. “Tori and Thuggernaut’s girl, Beverly, just decided to work together after tag-teaming a silver. Right now, they’re on their way to Beverly’s hideout to grab the cache she found. After that they’ll probably head back to the cave Tori dug.”

Ivan sat down in one of the many plush leather chairs Xelas stocked her room with—the mechanical woman was famously fond of entertaining guests—and took note of the two apprentices trekking through the hot desert sands. On the other monitors, he could see a thin young man trapping a silver-cored robot with a series of complicated symbols etched in the ground. The fourth of the group was nowhere to be found, though there was a massive consolidation of insects on top of one of the mesas, a churning miasma of fluttering wings.

“Lance—that’s Arachno Bro’s guy—has been pumping out bugs like nobody’s business, tracking and overwhelming coppers since yesterday. Warren is the one using magic—he’s Balaam’s, as I’m sure you know—and so far, he’s managed to bring down two silvers solo. Looks like he’s working on his third from what I can see.” Xelas effortlessly charted all the feeds, simultaneously watching the drama unfold from every angle as only one with a robotic brain could.

“It’s a sound, if slow, strategy,” Ivan said. “Though I highly doubt he’d be able to take down a gold-cored robot with such tactics. Nonetheless, from what you’ve described, it seems as though Balaam’s apprentice has a commanding lead.”

“For the moment.” Thuggernaut leaned forward from his own chair and scooped a pear cider from the open cooler resting in the middle of the floor. “There’s still a day and a half left though, and it looks like our students are the only ones who’ve figured out the importance of teamwork.”

“True; with no tech and only her powers to work with, Tori might be able to bring down a silver-cored on her own. Paired with someone who has power like Beverly, I can’t imagine they’ll have any trouble handling a challenge of that level,” Ivan agreed. “Even splitting the winnings, if they



make a conscious effort to go on the offensive, they'll easily pass the others in no time."

"Let's hope they manage to get a little practice in before sunset." Johnny nodded to the small clock at the top of the massive screen set before them. On it, a clock with golden numbers was slowly counting down toward zero. There were several hours remaining, yet second by second the time was falling away, as all time was wont to do.

Every person in the room already knew what would happen when time ran out, just as they had when the clock was silver in color and counting down on the prior day. The clock signaled the time remaining until the difficulty was going to be kicked up, when the next level of enemy would be released into the field. Gold-cored robots were hours from entry, and when the time for their entrance came, it would mark a real turning point in the training exercise.

Gold-cored robots were powerful enough that they could, and had, killed full members of the guild before. If an apprentice went against one unprepared, the class might just get a little bit smaller.

\* \* \*

"This is it." Beverly gestured to the cave, its entrance half-hidden in a mesa's shadow.

Tori stepped inside, pausing to marvel at the impressive method used to open up the area. Unlike her, Beverly had torn through rock rather than moving sand as the scattered remains of rubble and deep claw marks through the cave attested. It culminated in a far more intimidating, but also vastly smaller, space. Taking up a fair chunk of the limited room inside was a metal case identical to the one Tori had found in her own cavern, tucked carefully away lest anyone wandering by should notice its existence.

"Looks like we had the same idea," Tori remarked as she surveyed the surroundings. "I dug out a big hole in a place like this not too far away. Mine was a bit larger, though, so if you wanted to sleep in shifts tonight, we could stay there."

“I’ll think about it.” Beverly had clearly warmed to the idea of taking on robots with Tori’s help, but it seemed outright trust was still a point yet to be crossed.

Tori could hardly blame Beverly for the wariness—part of her wondered if reaching out like this would culminate in getting stabbed in the back. If so, then there wasn’t much to be done about it. Succeeding in this environment was going to require risk; that was obvious. She’d either have to take heavy chances with strategy fighting the robots or by trusting one of her fellow apprentices. This way, at least, seemed moderately less likely to get her killed. Since Beverly still appeared on the fence, Tori decided that it was time for a show of good faith, or as close to one as she could manage under the circumstances.

“Well, if you decide to take me up on it, at least I’ve got plenty of rations there. We wouldn’t have to haul anything over from your cache.” Meal bars and bottles of water weren’t the world’s best olive branch, but Beverly nodded in appreciation at the offer, so Tori counted it as a small victory. At least her fellow apprentice wouldn’t think she was trying to mooch. “Oh, and I had a scroll of some sort in mine too. My powers have nothing to do with magic, so I didn’t bother opening it, but if you can get some use out of it, then it’s all yours.”

“Are... are you sure about that?” Beverly’s large eyes widened even further, visibly taken aback by the unexpected display of generosity.

“Look, I’m not pretending to be a saint here. If I thought that thing would give me any kind of edge, I’d keep it for myself, but it’s useless in my hands. Maybe even dangerous. Better I hand it off to the person I’m working with instead. At this point, giving you a leg up helps me too.” Tori leaned slightly outside the small cave, scanning the area for any sign of movement that might indicate a robot attack. They’d run into a few copper-cored ones on just the walk over—pesky things seemed to be increasing by the hour.

“It might not be useful for me, either. The amulet has been confusing enough to try and figure out.” Beverly gestured to her neck, though whatever lay there was buried under the dark fabric of her

apprentice costume. “But I’ll take a look at it. Highly doubt it could make things much worse.”

Beverly walked over to her own metal box and undid the latch, flipping it open to reveal the remaining contents. She’d gone through more food and water than Tori had—which made sense since she couldn’t spend half her time in the form of living energy—but Beverly didn’t reach for any of the foodstuffs. Instead, she dug down to the bottom of the cache, eventually coming up with a small leather case. With a quick motion, she popped it open, and then held it out so Tori could get a good look inside.

“Mine didn’t have a scroll, but it did have this stuff. Couldn’t make heads or tails of what it was or how it was supposed to be used, though obviously it’s some sort of high-tech toolbox. Since we’re pooling resources, you can have it, as long as you can use it.”

Tori suppressed her desire to drool as she stared at the array of instruments before her. Most of the assortment laid out in the leather box was familiar to her, things she had lower-quality versions of in her own lab, but a few were new even to her. The only part that struck Tori as odd was that this was clearly a case meant for someone to tool around with advanced technology, yet the desert they were in was barren of materials.

The whirring sound of a passing copper-cored drone echoed across the landscape outside. Beverly checked over Tori’s shoulder to make sure it wasn’t getting close, her eyes already glowing their telltale green. For Tori however, the sound was not the harbinger of battle about to commence; it was a wake-up call correcting the misassumption she’d made only seconds prior. There were, in fact, tons of raw materials out in the desert, provided one had the combat acumen to procure them. That drone and all its siblings were stuffed with all manner of electronics Tori could twist to her own designs.

“I think I can get some solid use out of those,” Tori said at last, accepting the case and snapping it shut. “Let’s swing by my cave to drop this off and let you look at the scroll. After that, I want to get back into the field while we’ve still got daylight. If we work hard enough this afternoon, we may be able to kick the shit out of this place tomorrow.”

“Sounds like you’ve got a plan,” Beverly remarked. A coy, half-fanged smile danced on her lips as she remained partially shifted to her green dragon-form.

“Calling it a plan seems a bit grandiose; it’s more of an outline. But it all rests on laying the groundwork today.” Tori slipped the case down to her side and peeked carefully out of the cave. So long as she was carrying those precious tools, shifting to fire-form was out of the question.

“Given how little there is to do here, I’m going to take the wild guess that this groundwork centers on fighting robots,” Beverly said.

Tori shook her head then stepped back out into the sun’s burning light. “Not fighting. Hunting. There is a very key difference. You see, from here on out, we’re going to use every part of the robot buffalo.”

## Chapter 22

By the time evening fell, Tori and Beverly had managed to down six of the silver-cored robots and a dozen or so more coppers. It was rough going at first as they gained a better sense of how to combat the spherical enemies as well as how to work together. During the first two battles, there were times when their attacks overlapped, each nearly striking the other. Those were tenuous, dangerous seconds during which their fragile alliance easily could have shattered. The need to win, however, drowned out any petty squabbling that might have occurred, and by the time their opponent was down, all thoughts of dissolution were driven from their minds.

As the day wore on, coming closer and closer to dusk, their teamwork grew stronger. Each woman began to understand the other's natural attack style, and they soon fell into a rhythm. Tori darted in and out, zipping around to draw attention while Beverly charged in and smashed the most pivotal pieces of the robot's anatomy. By the time they killed their sixth silver-cored robot, they were functioning like a well-calibrated machine themselves, tearing through the last opponent in only a few minutes.

Much of a roll as they were on, neither wanted to press their luck as the sun began to set. Surprise was the element that had given them the most edge in their fights. With Tori standing out like a beacon against the dark sky, that aspect of battle would be turned against them. Better to hole up, rest, and conserve strength for the next day's fights.

They made it back to Tori's cave just as the last specks of sunlight were fading from the horizon, covering the desert in a blanket of stars and darkness. It would have been an easier and faster trip, if not for the fact that Beverly was forced to spend it hauling most of the mechanical remains from one of their silver-cored opponents across the desert. When they finally reached the cave, she set it carefully down outside, and then shifted from her green dragon-form back to the lovely, weary young woman Tori had first met.

“All right, that’s four of the damn things. If you can’t work with that, drag the next one yourself.” Beverly made a show of stretching her back and arms, despite the fact that they weren’t really all that tired. She was still learning about her dragon powers, but her green form seemed almost impervious to fatigue.

“Should be plenty,” Tori assured her. “With this much raw material, I think I can whip together a useful tool or two by sunrise. How about you? Going to take another crack at the scroll?”

“Maybe after dinner.” Beverly had already opened the scroll stuffed in Tori’s cache, though there hadn’t been any effect that they could discern. After a few minutes of study, Beverly came to the conclusion that whatever magic lay amid the arcane runes burned into the parchment would require some sort of activation. Since daylight had been dwindling, she put it away as a project to look at during her time on guard duty.

With night upon them, both women turned their attention to fighting hunger and dehydration by downing most of the remaining supplies stashed in Tori’s metal box. If they wanted to last another day in the desert, it would mean either relocating to Beverly’s hideout or hauling over her supplies. Each could easily go without the food and water for a day if needed, but constant combat would take its toll unless they were properly sated.

“What’s your deal anyway?” Beverly asked as she dug into her third meal bar. It seemed the slender woman either burned a lot of calories while in her dragon-form or possessed the not-so-super ability of having a tapeworm. “You’ve got a really cool ability where you turn into fire, but you want to spend the night tinkering around with busted robot parts?”

For a brief moment, Tori contemplated hiding her plans for the salvaged components, concealing her true abilities from this woman who might end up being her competition. That idea was quickly tossed aside, primarily because Beverly would quickly see Tori’s talents when her devices were used but also because lying seemed a poor choice. Ivan appeared to have a lot of friends in the guild; if Beverly made it to full member status along with her, Tori could use a few comrades of her own. That sort of relationship was built on trust, though, especially among villains.

“I’m actually more of a tech-head than a fire-user. Right now I’m working on a meta-suit, and I’ve been inventing more or less since childhood. Truth be told, I really don’t like using my powers this much, but Pseudonym wouldn’t let me bring any of my gear.”

“Living off the land seems to be the theme of this weekend. Well, sort of.” Beverly took a long draw from a bottle of water, emptying it out and setting it aside. “I guess I can see why you’re supposed to be a big deal, though. Having those powers and the smarts to build your own tech... that’s a hell of a combo.”

“My teacher is the big deal, not me,” Tori quickly corrected. “And the only reason I got him was that no one else wanted me. My attitude is seen as ‘problematic’ and ‘uncooperative’ and other shit like that. I mean, I still think I’m awesome, but I doubt anyone else in the guild really believes that. Not yet, anyway.”

“Thuggernaut thinks pretty highly of Pseudonym, that’s for sure. As strong as my teacher is, I get the feeling he’s a little wowed by yours,” Beverly said.

“He is something of a legend.” Tori finished choking down her lone meal bar, the texture roughly akin to what she imagined eating Styrofoam would be like. “But tell me about Thuggernaut; I’ve only gotten to meet him in passing. Is he really as strong as he looks?”

“More,” Beverly replied. “That first night when I ran into Thuggernaut, I thought I was going to kill him. After a couple weeks of training, I realized that the only thing holding him back was him trying not to seriously injure me. I’m really lucky he took me on as an apprentice, otherwise I doubt I’d have even this much control over all this... stuff.”

“I don’t mean to pry, and if this is overstepping, I understand, but I have to ask. Since you seem to view these powers as more burden than blessing, why not just take off the necklace?”

Wordlessly reaching up to the top of her costume, Beverly carefully undid a clasp and pulled the neckline open, exposing the top of her sternum. Her dark skin was smooth and flawless at first, but then a pattern began to

glow with silver light. In moments the symbol, which ran up around her throat like a necklace, had lit the cave with a soft, candle-like glow.

“Nothing to take off. The moment I put the necklace on, it fused with me. Thuggernaut’s brought me to every person he trusts in the magic division, and none of them have any idea how to separate me from it. Like it or not, for now, I’m stuck with these powers. If I want any shot at my old life back, it means getting them under control.”

Tori nodded her head at the three torn-apart robots resting just outside the cave door. “Seems to me you’ve got things pretty well in hand.”

“Being the dragons is the easy part; it’s keeping them at bay that’s tough. Every time I get scared or mad or surprised, I can feel them pushing to get out.” Beverly bowed her head. The intricate silver tattoo faded away, plunging them once more into darkness. “I’m making progress, though. There was a time I couldn’t even get it to disappear, which would have really cut down on my wardrobe options.”

“Not to mention swimsuits would pretty much be out, unless you could dig out one of those giant frilly dress ones from the thirties,” Tori added.

“Yeah, that shit was not happening. I don’t do frills or ruffles, no exceptions.” Beverly glanced out the opening of the cave, taking in the soft night sky. “For what it’s worth, I’m glad I ran into you today. This has been a lot easier with someone to watch my back.”

“Imagine how we could have torn through this if everyone worked together,” Tori replied.

“Wish in one hand, spit in the other.” Beverly’s eyes began to glow, this time scarlet instead of their usual emerald green. “If you want to bed down, I can take first watch. My red dragon has solid night vision.”

“Thanks, but I’d rather get to work.” Tori stood from her sandy seat and walked over to the cave’s rear where the case holding those precious tools was stashed. “I’ve got too many ideas whizzing around in my head. Even if I wanted to sleep, I doubt—”



The explosion was far enough off that neither woman thought they were under attack, though they did both react immediately to the threatening sound. Tori dropped the case, her body turning to flames before the metal even hit the soft, sandy floor of the cave. Beverly's body lengthened and grew, covered with bright red scales as she took on the only one of her forms Tori had yet to witness. Both peered out the narrow doorway for a few seconds, waiting for more explosions or the sound of approaching enemies.

After a few minutes of peace, Beverly leaned out, sniffing the air carefully as she scanned the thick night. Eventually, she pulled herself back in and shed her inhuman-form, an expression of worry draped across her face.

"There's a faint scent of smoke coming from the southwest, but it seems pretty far off. Nothing approaching, as far as I can tell. Best guess is that one of the boys decided to try and do a little night-hunting to grab more cores."

"Let's hope so." Tori shifted from living fire to perfectly normal-looking young woman, although her brain was still shooting adrenaline through her system. "Well, I wasn't anywhere near sleep before, and now it's definitely not happening."

"No kidding." Beverly's eyes still glowed with a faint red light as she made her way across the cave, lying down with her head against the rock wall at the rear, gazing directly out the entrance. "I may stay up for a while and watch you work. Just until my nerves settle."

"Feel free," Tori told her. "But fair warning, when I get in the zone, I'm not very chatty."

Beverly reached out to the nearby metal box and plucked the scroll from its depths, carefully unrolling it between her narrow fingers. "Somehow, I think I'll manage."

\* \* \*

Lance limped through the desert, only his myriad of insect helpers supporting him. His leg was probably broken; enough high school football

had taught him the basics of what such injuries felt like. He couldn't manage to put even the smallest amount of weight on the limb, so that was also a dead giveaway. The swarm of dragonflies and bees pushing upward on his left shoulder acted as a makeshift crutch, giving him what he only prayed would be enough mobility to complete his escape.

All those sentries and scouts he'd positioned around the desert and none had given Lance adequate warning. That robot had come after him like there was a target on his chest, turning so many of his conjured minions to ash under its laser blast. Those that survived served as a smokescreen to cover his escape, which was more falling off the top of a mesa than any daring plan to make himself scarce. Whatever that robot was, Lance knew from the moment it arrived that he wasn't going to be able to win the fight.

The silver-cored ones had been challenge enough; he'd had to practically choke their interior electronics with swarm after swarm of insect sacrifices to shut them down. This one didn't seem keen on letting anything get close, not even a seemingly harmless bug. Lance couldn't imagine how any of the four apprentices were going to be able to take it down. If the other three were that far out of his league that they could dispatch something that powerful solo, what was the point of making him train alongside them?

Lance would have slowed down as the realization struck him if he could have afforded to. Tori had been right from the beginning; they were supposed to work together. It was the only way any of them had even half a hope of stopping something that strong. Lance cursed himself for not listening then turned his attention away from the mistake and on to what could still be done.

Raising his right hand, Lance conjured a handful of assorted flying bugs and tossed them into the air. There was a day left yet. If he could find Tori or one of the others, maybe he could convince them to team up with him. True, he was injured, but his power had never been physically-based in the first place. Even if they demanded some of his orbs in exchange for working together, it would be worth it.

By Lance's reckoning, that robot he'd fought was either a gold or platinum core. If it was platinum, that was bad enough, but if it was gold,

then they were in a world of shit. A gold-cored robot doing that much damage meant he hadn't even seen the final opponents, and with the way they seemed to exponentially grow in difficulty, Lance wasn't sure he'd survive a platinum encounter.

With his bugs on the wind searching for those who might be allies, Lance focused on limping along as fast as he could, desperately searching for somewhere he could lie low until sunrise.

\* \* \*

Ivan sat in his living room, a glass of sweet tea in his hand as he watched the evening news. Beth was asleep upstairs, worn out from her long day, and Rick had snuck out his window only a half hour prior. It was always tempting to bust his son when he clumsily tripped through wards and traps that would have incinerated him had they not been keyed to leave him alone, but Ivan resisted. He had, after all, once been that age, and the trouble he'd gotten into was far worse than anything Rick was likely to manage. Ivan followed him on occasion, staying to the shadows and keeping watch to make sure intervention wasn't needed. Usually, all Rick did was sneak over to a friend's house or to the parking lot of a local gas station where he would hang out with the same friends. All teenagers went through some form of rebellion; at least Rick's was largely harmless.

Still, Ivan planned to catch him when he came home tonight. Rebellion had risks, and getting caught came with consequences. He couldn't stay on top of his son all the time, not if he wanted Rick to learn how to live on his own, but Ivan knew too well the problems that came for those without limits. Occasionally catching and grounding him would remind his son that there were rules in his life, curfew included, and breaking them still had consequences.

A video of the daring rescue from a few days prior cycled across the television screen. The various news outlets had been playing the fight footage ad nauseam, no doubt at the AHC's urging. While none of the old guard went in much for that sort of promotion, it was common knowledge that the founding three were getting more and more hands-off as time wore on. The media relations team was likely almost completely comprised of

younger, more ambitious capes, eager to make their organization seem like the gold standard in superpowered heroics.

Technically, none of the original three needed to step away from their leading roles. Quorum's age was slowed down to a point where it was nearly irrelevant, Professor Quantum seemed to have found a way to permanently lock his appearance to that of a late forty-something, and Lodestar... well, Ivan understood why she'd let her position in the organization diminish. Life was often cruel in its little tricks, offering gifts with price tags not understood until long after they'd been accepted. Not that she'd ever really been given a choice. Lodestar's power was thrust upon her. She wasn't like the hungry ones who'd sought it out. She wasn't like Ivan.

Ivan's mind turned, as it had ceaselessly since the weekend's inception, back to his apprentice and the trial she was undergoing. Tori had been doing well when he left Xelas's room, having paired up with Beverly to fight the silver-cored robots. She was a smart woman and had made finding a place to hide top priority. There was little chance she'd be caught unaware once the gold-cored machines were released, and even if she was, at least she had backup. Beverly seemed to be an exceptional meta herself, and Ivan had implicit trust in Thuggernaut's guiding hand. The two of them together could likely overcome a gold just as they were, albeit not without some injuries. If they managed to make use of the supplemental supplies in their caches, they'd be able to pull it off without issue.

Though, Ivan still planned to look in on them again tomorrow after Janet picked up the kids. It was simply good form for her teacher to be waiting when the trial was done, after all.

## Chapter 23

“You know, in spite of the green scales and leathery skin, I’m not actually a purse, right?” Beverly slung the makeshift sling and its bulky contents around her shoulder and fastened it in place as best she could. It still bounced and rustled when she moved, but at least it seemed to stay on her.

“I’d love to help out, but since neither the scroll nor the robot parts were made of morphing materials, they won’t turn to fire with me. That means if I’m carrying I either stay totally human—and therefore useless—or go into fire-form and drop or burn everything I’ve got.” To illustrate the point, Tori switched to the incarnation of living flame and ran her hand along the cave wall, leaving a scorch mark behind.

“Guess they gave you a uniform made of the morph stuff,” Beverly said, taking note for the first time that Tori’s clothes changed with her. “Makes sense. Mine’s made to shrink and expand as needed. Too bad it didn’t come with a backpack.” She adjusted the sling once more, and the two women stepped from the safety of their cave into the early morning sunlight.

“We going after more silvers today?” Beverly asked, her eyes already beginning to shift into the white iris of her flying dragon-form.

“Or whatever is out there. Given the explosions we heard last night, I wouldn’t be surprised if someone fought their first gold. Maybe even platinum. Can’t afford to fall behind.”

“Especially not since we have to split our winnings.” Beverly’s skin lightened as scales appeared from its formerly smooth depths. “I’ll do the usual circle around, see what’s visible, and then come back so we can start moving toward our target.”

“Perfect. Meet you on top of that mesa.” Tori pointed upward to one of the many patches of raised land surrounding them and then began to push off the ground using controlled blasts of flame. After discovering the new

technique on the prior day, she'd become determined to get as much practice as possible while safely away from civilization. While flight didn't come as easily for her as it clearly did for Beverly, there was still a primal thrill in ignoring the limits of gravity and soaring, or carefully bobbing, through the air. One day, she'd make a meta-suit that would slice across the sky, but this would do until then.

Beverly nodded, finishing the transformation. Her white dragon-form was as large as the others, though in place of her arms, a pair of massive, leathery wings extended from her torso. With one kick from her mighty hind legs, she leapt into the sky, quickly pulling herself higher with a few powerful flaps. In seconds, she'd risen high enough that Tori had trouble distinguishing her fellow apprentice from the white clouds.

Turning her attention to her own ascent, Tori slowly rose upward toward the predetermined mesa, so intent on keeping stabilized that she didn't even notice the wasp, clearly not indigenous to the area, that buzzed by and abruptly stopped as soon as it saw her.

\* \* \*

He'd found her. Not just a fellow apprentice, which would have been good enough, but the only one to advocate working together. She was some ways out—it would take him an hour or so to reach her—but at least he had a location. The wasp would stay on her, and he could adjust his course as she moved. While there was no denying this was a long shot, it was still a shot. And he'd take what he could get.

Poking his head out from under the shelf of rock where he'd taken cover, Lance slowly pulled himself up from the dirt. His leg hurt even more than it had last night, and the rest of his body had begun to add its own lyrics to the symphony of pain. Taking that kind of tumble, even with his swarm to slow his fall, had left Lance with more injuries than he'd realized. It was an important issue, one that warranted dealing with... something he fully intended to do as soon as the trial was over. Until then, he would soldier on. If anything, it would just make his eventual triumph all the more impressive.

The thought of coming out on top in spite of his bruised and battered body was all that gave Lance the strength to push himself forward. The

crutch of bugs was back in place, its individual denizens more numerous than before thanks to a few hours of summoning under the cover of night. Lance hobbled forward, cutting a brisker pace than the day before, eyes set on the sunrise. Soon he'd reach Tori and hopefully be able to make a case for teaming up. If he was lucky, she'd have seen the robot he fought already; that thing made the case all on its own. Either way, he'd feel better once he wasn't out in the open, alone.

Lance just had to hope the robot didn't find him before then.

\* \* \*

Tori barely made it onto the mesa before she heard a roar rip through the sky. Glancing upward, she caught sight of Beverly tucked into a dive, careening toward the mesa at breakneck speed. There was a moment of total, unmediated confusion as she watched her partner on what seemed like a death dive for no reason. Then, from behind the cover of a cloud, the robot came into view.

It was smaller than the silver-cored ones, but slightly larger than Beverly in her current form. Unlike the others, however, this one was human-shaped. As Tori watched, it raised its right hand at the fleeing dragon, releasing a bolt of red energy directly at her. Beverly, operating on what had to be sheer instinct by this point, tucked her wings and rolled, avoiding the blast by mere inches. The red bolt tore through a nearby mesa, causing a massive explosion and showering the whole area in fragments of broken rock.

*That* was a hell of a weapon. This was no nonlethal armament like the silver's sonic cannon. It was meant to kill, albeit messily. And if that's the tool it was opening with, Tori had to assume there was more powerful gear stashed away in its metal body.

Beverly skidded to a stop on top of the mesa, her powerful claws leaving deep grooves in the rock as she killed the momentum from her dive. Before she'd even fully stopped her scales began changing from pearly white to an emerald green, wings vanishing in exchange for thick, muscular arms. Reaching up with one newly-altered appendage, Beverly sliced through the knot on the makeshift sling, sending it tumbling to the ground

with a rattling thud. Swiveling her reptilian head toward Tori, Beverly spoke—the first time she’d done so in a dragon-form since they met.

“It’s strong.” Beverly’s voice was harsh and rough, like a rattlesnake who’d managed to evolve vocal cords.

“I can see that.” Tori watched the robot descend, both of its arms raised and ready to fire, no doubt waiting for the opportune shot. “Can you buy me enough time to use my gun?”

“Use it fast.” She whipped her head back around, keeping a watchful eye on the robot as it landed across the mesa, its arms still raised. Without another word, the green dragon-woman barreled forward, racing toward the mechanical opponent that had chased her out of the sky.

Before she’d even made it three steps, the robot fired off a bolt of focused blue energy from its left hand that crackled as it cut through the air. Beverly wasn’t entirely able to get out of this one’s way, and she roared in pain as it burned through part of her bicep. As much as it hurt, she kept right on barreling forward, refusing to be stopped so easily. Green blood dripped from her arm as she rushed to close the gap.

While Beverly charged, Tori shifted back to human-form and hurriedly dug through the sling on the ground. During her evening of turning salvaged parts into workable electronics, Tori had imagined the adversaries she might use her inventions on when the sun rose. In her mind, though, the situation hadn’t been quite so desperate nor had it come so soon. But what her imagination had failed to anticipate in terms of setting, it had certainly accounted for regarding necessary power. Jerking her invention free of the sling, Tori turned just in time to see Beverly getting into range for a melee attack.

As the powerful green monster tore across the mesa’s rock surface, the metallic humanoid watched her come. It squeezed off one more blue energy shot, which Beverly managed to dodge. It quickly became clear that this was not a fight that would take place over a long range; Beverly fully intended to use those powerful claws and muscles against the robot’s comparatively slender form. Just as she was one step away from paying back the damage she’d taken, her metallic opponent leapt upward, taking flight and putting itself completely out of her range.



“Right idea,” Tori muttered, carefully drawing a bead on her now-floating target. “Wrong opponents.” She pulled the barely-fastened trigger and the entire apparatus she had braced against her shoulder began to vibrate. With enough time and parts, she could have built in stabilizers to get rid of the device’s shaking, but those were luxuries not afforded to her. Instead, Tori grit her teeth and kept her aim, refusing to lose this chance. There was no guarantee they’d get another.

The reason Tori had wanted to go after the silver-cored robots wasn’t just because of their size. She’d wanted a sonic cannon of her own from the instant one knocked her all the way back to being human. Of course, the ones inside the bots were too big for her to carry, let alone wield. That was why she’d spent the night piecing together a version that was smaller, light enough that even she could utilize it. Of course, with a bit of ingenuity and four robots’ worth of parts to work with, Tori had done more than just shrink the cannons. She’d also cranked up their output.

As the sonic blast tore through the air, a massive wall of vibration that slammed into the floating robot as it took aim at the dragon below, Tori was glad she’d given it all the stopping power she could. Even as their opponent seemed to lose control and fell toward the mesa once more, she didn’t trust it... she wouldn’t until the thing was torn into pieces and scattered through the sand.

“Beverly!”

Tori’s shout was all her partner needed; the dragon-woman was already reared back and ready to jump. The moment Tori screamed, Beverly leapt, meeting the humanoid in midair with an audible crunch. Her claws were tearing through its torso and her powerful jaws were crushing through its left shoulder before they even hit the ground. Whether this was payback or pragmatism was up for debate, but there could be no doubt it was effective. The two slammed into the rocky top of the mesa, sending a spray of dust and rock everywhere.

While the adversaries fought, Tori dug through the sling once again. She pulled the smoking circuit board out of her makeshift sonic cannon and threw it to the ground. Overclocking the device came with a serious drawback: the internal system got fried after every shot. Since she’d had

four robots to salvage from, she only had four chances to fire her cannon. Well, three, now.

Slamming the second circuit board into position, Tori quickly aimed at the dissipating cloud of dust. Firing into the fray was only going to be a last ditch effort. Large as the blasts were, she'd definitely hit Beverly if another shot was needed, but that would be a far better fate for her than taking one of the robot's explosive shots at point blank range.

A wave of relief washed over Tori as the dust finally fell away to reveal Beverly, still in her green dragon-form, standing over what looked more like an upended bin of spare parts than the remains of an actual robot. In her claw, shining bright in the mid-morning sun, was a golden orb the same size as the lesser ones they'd already collected. Tori lowered her gun back to the ground and made her way across the mesa, intent on checking out the remains for herself.

"You didn't leave me much to work with, did you?" A few rogue sparks still crackled from the debris that had only moments ago been a deadly opponent, but there was little chance of it suddenly springing back to life and attacking them. Not unless it was built to self-repair or was actually made of far, *far* tinier robots all working together.

"All that sonic blast did was stun it. Bastard was already getting its shit together when I attacked. Decided not to take any chances." Beverly's voice had lost its husky quality. Tori glanced over and found herself staring at the human version of her fellow apprentice, no worse for the wear despite her injuries.

"Do you need me to look at your arm?" Tori offered.

"It's fine." Beverly pulled back her sleeve to show a bare, unmarked bicep. "I told you, my green dragon is tough and can heal like nobody's business. I'm just glad he didn't get off another one of those red explosion shots while I was coming at him."

"I'll have to look it over to be sure, but I'd wager it didn't because it couldn't. Attacks that strong take a lot of juice; it probably needed to recharge after the first shot." Tori hunkered down in a squat and began sifting through the claw- and tooth-marked remains. "There's other stuff in

here, too. Shield system that it didn't get to use thanks to the cannon, smaller weapons, even a few for melee. Keep watch while I pick through this."

"Think you'll find something you can use?" Beverly asked.

Tori shook her head. Even if there'd been time, Beverly had done too good a job turning her opponent into scrap. "Nothing physical, but if I'm lucky, I might see what little tricks this one was hiding. That way the next one won't take us by surprise."

"Take your time, then." Beverly's eyes began to glow white as scales manifested over her body. "There's bound to be a lot of those out there. I'd like to see how many we can take down."

\* \* \*

"And first kill on the golds goes to Thuggernaut's apprentice, with Pseudonym's getting a respectable assist," Johnny announced. While he was still wearing a pinstriped suit, it was at least a different one than the day before.

"An assist? What fight were you watching?" Xelas made a motion to the wall; one of the screens began to rewind until it was showing Tori's blast once more. "Without that shot, dragon-girl had no chance of making the hit. If anything, Tori got the kill and Beverly got the assist."

"Tori's contribution was invaluable, that's why she gets an assist." Johnny pulled out the laptop he'd brought along and made a few quick keystrokes, updating the betting pool along with how much he stood to make himself. This was a big one; almost no one had picked Beverly for the first kill of a gold-cored. "The one who spills the blood, or in this case circuits, gets the credit. You know it as well as I do."

"Johnny is right," Gork said. Her voice was nearly as rough as her words were heavy. Gork's people had a heavy emphasis on honor and protocol, which made her quite a stickler for the rules... or at least the ones she agreed to follow. When it came to matters of fairness, regarding both the letter and spirit of their rules, Gork was universally considered as impartial a judge as could be found in a guild full of criminals and outlaws.

Had the AHC greeted Gork as a friend instead of assuming her people were a threat, they might have gained powerful allies beneath the Earth's crust. Unfortunately, force had won over diplomacy, and Gork's culture had *very* firm ideas about dealing with unwarranted aggression.

"See, from the part-rock woman's mouth herself." Finishing his entry, Johnny slid the laptop back into the bag by his feet and turned his attention to the screens once more. "That said: it was one hell of an assist. Can't believe the gal put together something like that out of spare parts in a single night."

"I'm starting to see why she's so insistent on being in Wade's department," Xelas agreed. "I've got a few upgrades in mind I've been tinkering with, might have to see if she has any thoughts worth sharing."

"No loading the rookies with too much work until they actually become full members," Gork reminded her.

Xelas crossed her arms and frowned, an exaggerated gesture that set off red lights around her cheeks. "Stop trying to rain on all my fun. First you break up a me-and-Johnny fight, now you tell me I can't use an apprentice for grunt work."

"I just said you had to wait to do that," Gork pointed out. "If you can't be more creative in your hazing, then you really don't deserve to mess with them anyway. This is *you* we're talking about."

"Ouch, foiled by my own reputation. Fine. I'll find more ways to amuse myself at their expense," Xelas conceded. "I plan to take it easy on Pseudonym and Thuggernaut's kids, though. They seem the type to want payback and are a little more competent than I prefer my victims."

"Beverly definitely is," Thuggernaut confirmed. "And while I don't know Tori that well, she *has* survived as Pseudonym's apprentice for nearly a month."

Xelas looked back at the screen where Tori was pulling apart one of the larger pieces of the robot's chest, trying to crack open an undamaged section of its electronics. "Let's hope he wasn't going easy on her. There's still daylight left before this thing is done."

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## Chapter 24

Warren slid his back along the rocky wall separating him from the hovering, human-shaped robot currently scanning for his location. The symbol he'd drawn on his torso cloaked him from most of its sensors—at least, he hoped so—but the spell wasn't strong enough to keep him safe if the thing caught sight of him. He'd been overconfident; taking down a half-dozen silvers on his own had bolstered Warren's opinion of his abilities, and he'd gone up against the new opponent without enough research. To say that had backfired would be like saying Fornax had been mildly disliked by the local police during his heyday. As it was, Warren desperately needed to escape, regroup, and strategize. Despite the wounds on his legs and the blood dripping from his chest, Warren still believed he could win against what he assumed was a gold-cored robot.

But it would require planning, preparation, and time to heal, none of which he was likely to have if that thing caught hold of him. Balaam had made it clear—this was not a gentle trial. No one was waiting in the wings to leap in and save him. It was just as it was in the real world: to fail was to die. And Warren didn't intend to die. Not in this robot-infested desert, not for failing to impress the guild, not under Balaam's heel for not living up to his expectations.

Warren would survive. It was what he did. What he had always done. The only difference now was that the stakes were higher. That, and the fact that Warren finally had some power of his own to swing around.

Dipping his finger into one of the many wounds torn open by rock debris from the explosion, he began to scrawl a new symbol on the wall behind him. It took a few more dips in the leg wound to get enough blood, but eventually, he finished his work. He pressed his hand to the symbol and it immediately began to glow, just as the matching one he'd scrawled days before did. That symbol resided on a small outcropping between two mesas over a mile away, sheltered from elements and sight.

When the glow faded, Warren was no longer anywhere near the robot that had attacked him. The symbol, its work completed, crumbled into dust that caught on the late morning breeze. Seconds after he vanished, the only proof Warren had ever been standing there at all was the small pool of blood drying in the sand.

\* \* \*

Hunting the golds was much different than going after the silvers. Silver-cored robots, formidable as they were, excelled in a castle-style defense. They were big and well-armored but suffered from poor mobility. Golds took an opposite approach: they zipped through the sky as they searched for targets, preferably ones they could catch unaware. In a way, their technique was similar to the copper-cored drones from the first day, though those were obviously far easier to handle.

This meant that Beverly couldn't fly around scanning from a safe distance for targets like they'd done for the silvers, going airborne now came with serious risks. Since it would make her vulnerable in one of her weaker forms, the women quickly brushed aside the idea of having Beverly do any more solo air scouting. Instead, they decided to use the fact that they were being hunted to their advantage.

Beverly waited patiently atop a mesa in her red dragon-form, scanning the sky for any flying enemies. When one was spotted, she would let loose a blast of flame in its direction. These attacks were, of course, much too far away to be effective, but they succeeded in their true purpose of drawing the robot's attention to her. As it would get close, the gold-cored would take a few shots at Beverly, who would immediately shift to her green form. At such a long range, she was easily able to dodge any attacks, even the red blasts. This helped them to gain some critical information: Tori had correctly assumed that the red blasts needed to be recharged after firing. Finding its tactics ineffective, the robot would then drop height, seeking to shorten the range of the shots and remove Beverly's ability to dodge.

That was when Tori took her shot, blasting it from her hidden nearby position with the sonic cannon. With its shields down since it thought it was safe, the robot was stunned long enough for Beverly to attack, shredding it to pieces just as she had the first.

Their first attempt at using the strategy was rough: Tori nearly missed due to the robot's last-minute shift, and Beverly wasn't quite quick enough off the line. The robot had nearly regained its senses by the time she arrived, which made for a tense moment as she attacked, uncertain whether her opponent would be able to activate its defenses in time. Luck was on their side, though, and the metallic enemy dropped to the ground as mere scrap metal under Beverly's assault.

The second attempt went much more smoothly; the poor robot never even had a chance.

"Three cores down." Beverly pulled the golden orb from the scattered electrical remains, her claws and glowing eyes the only remains of the dragon-form she'd shed moments prior. "That's fifteen hundred apiece. Not too shabby for a long weekend of work."

"You're counting wrong." Tori yanked the circuit board free as she walked over, dropping it to the ground like the trash it now was and pulling out their last functioning unit. "Since killing this many means we'll win, one of us should turn in all the cores, getting the bonus. That turns three thousand into forty-five hundred, netting us two thousand, two hundred and fifty dollars apiece, plus some extra from the silvers."

Beverly stared carefully at the half-distracted woman as she tucked the orb away in her pocket with the others. Their partnership had worked out well so far, but they'd yet to reach the point that would truly test it. When money and credit were on the line, there was always the chance that one of them would decide alliances were worth less than what could be won.

"And which of us would do the claiming?"

"Since you obviously think I'm doing this as some sort of trick, why don't you turn them in?" Tori suggested as she loaded the final board into place. One shot left on the sonic cannon, and since they hadn't seen many silvers out since the prior night, it was best not to expect any chances at reloading.

"You'd trust me to just give you your cut? Not to mention giving up all the credit for these kills?"



“Trust me, the guild knows exactly who killed what. They’ve probably watched everything we’ve done since arrival. The only people who would think more of me for turning in a bunch of orbs are you three, and I think there are already enough expectations being thrown my way as it is.” Tori set her cannon down before turning to face Beverly properly. “And yes, I will trust you with collecting the money. Best case scenario, you and I build a little more trust between us, something that is very useful to have in this place. Worst case scenario, you betray me and I learn you’re not to be trusted. Two thousand dollars isn’t a cheap lesson, but better I learn it now before it costs me far more down the road.”

Stepping away from the robotic wreckage, Beverly shook her head and let out a muted chuckle. “Jesus Christ, it’s kind of creepy how logical you are. Sure you aren’t part Vulcan?”

“Nah, Spock wasn’t that big on revenge. I’d definitely make you pay for screwing me over. But I don’t really think it’s going to come to that,” Tori said.

“This place is already weird and scary enough. Last thing I need is someone with a grudge against me... especially when that person could be an ally instead.” Beverly stuck out her hand and Tori grasped it, giving a firm shake.

“I like to think we could even make it all the way to becoming friends,” Tori added. “From what I’ve seen, having those is half of what it takes to survive in this guild.”

“In that case, I suspect you’re about to find my proposal very interesting.”

This voice came from neither Beverly nor Tori. Both spun toward its source, Tori’s whole body immediately morphing into living flame while green scales engulfed Beverly’s form. What met their eyes was not a threat, or at least not something that seemed particularly threatening.

Lance sat on the edge of the mesa, hands high in the air in a motion of clear surrender, a swarm of bugs helping keep him balanced as he rested. “I come in peace. Is that Star Trek? Damn it, I knew I should have watched

those shows. Point is, I don't want trouble. I came to talk about working together."

Tori slowly lowered her hands and the fireballs burning at the ready in her palms, though she didn't turn back to her human-form just yet. Taking in the man before her, she noted that his leg looked to be in rough shape, and he had the weary, hunkered appearance of someone fighting sleep deprivation and dehydration.

"You barely look like you can sit up straight; meanwhile, we're taking out golds with ease. Feels less like you want to talk about teaming up and more like us dragging you along."

"True, I'm far from in peak condition, but my power has never been one that required me to do much dirty work. Besides, from the number of circuit boards left and what I saw through my bugs, I'd guess that fancy shooter of yours is on its last bullet, so you'll have to change strategies soon. I can lend a hand with that on the combat side, or at least my bugs can. And on top of that, I bring something to the table that neither of you has: surveillance and tracking. Imagine if you knew where those gold-cored robots were at any given time. Might make getting around and hunting them a lot easier."

"He talks a good game," Beverly said, words a half-snarl through her scaly snout. "But how do we know he can back it up?"

A single wasp flitted through the air, rising from Beverly's back and floating until it landed on Lance's outstretched finger. He smiled as the realization dawned on the others and considered letting the moment speak for itself, but ultimately decided to really drive the point home. "I found you, didn't I?"

Tori slowly shifted back to her human-form, then walked over and picked up the sonic cannon. While she didn't actually point it at him, the implied threat was more than enough. Tori didn't need words to drive her points home, not when they were better used for making her demands.

"All right, Lance, tell us what you're thinking."

\* \* \*

“Beth, don’t forget your phone charger.” Ivan’s voice echoed up the hall into what he only hoped would be his daughter’s room and mind. Well-intentioned though she was, Beth couldn’t seem to keep track of her chargers no matter what lengths he and Janet went to. Were she a more malicious child, he’d have suspected the losses were intentional simply because he couldn’t fathom one person genuinely going through so many.

The upstairs bustled as the sounds of packing filled the air. It often seemed like his children had barely arrived before they were stuffing their lives back into suitcases and heading out the door. During those moments, Ivan had to force himself to remember how lucky he was to have even the weekends he did. After all, it wasn’t as though Janet didn’t have good cause to dispute the joint custody. He liked to think it was respect for his parenting abilities that kept her from trying to keep his children away, but in his heart of hearts, Ivan always suspected that fear was her primary motivator. While he would never hurt his children by taking away their mother, Janet likely still believed that crossing him so severely would be bad for her health.

Sometimes, it was hard to remember the harsh, worried woman as the wild girl who’d had a thing for bad boys. Time had changed her, as it had him, and as it did all, eventually. There were many moments in Ivan’s life he’d have altered given the chance, but his time with Janet was certainly not among them. Not for fond memories of her, which a bad marriage and worse divorce had soured. No, Ivan wouldn’t dare risk changing the past because it might steal from him two of the only things in the world he truly cared about.

Rick came bustling down the stairs, bag slung over his shoulder, phone conspicuously absent from his hand. His and Ivan’s discussion the prior night had been a long one, heavy on responsibility and trust, and while it ended with a grounding, such was done more in service to formal rule observation than out of anger. Ivan wanted his son to understand the importance of consequences; it was a lesson his life would have been better served if he’d learned it earlier. As the young man, the near spitting image of Ivan at that age (sans a few scars and pounds of muscle) reached the end of the stairs, he looked up at his father with a touch of embarrassment.

“Dad, I just wanted to say I’m sorry again about last night.”

“We went over everything, and it’s fine. You know what you did wrong, and you’re paying for it. So long as the lesson is learned, there’s no need to keep raking yourself over the coals.” Ivan grabbed his son and wrapped the boy in a powerful hug. “Just don’t go thinking you can slip past your old man so easily.”

“Trust me, I’ve got that figured out.” Rick hugged back, even though they both knew it was only a matter of time before he tried something again. This was the age where he tested his limits. Few people in the world understood that better than Ivan.

“Daaaad, have you seen my charger?” The voice carried down from upstairs, causing Ivan to wince while in mid-hug. He glanced down at Rick, who quickly shook his head to the negative. Wordlessly, he reached into a drawer on the desk resting at the foyer’s edge and removed one of a half-dozen identical white cords with specialized ends.

“It’s down here!” Ivan called upstairs. He pressed a finger to his lips and stared pointedly at Rick, who took the message. “You left it on the kitchen counter.”

The goal was not to teach his son not to lie, but that lies were tools best used for purposes that suited them. Keeping a young girl from worrying over the loss of yet another cord, for example, was an excellent use of a well-timed lie. As was what he’d told them both he planned to spend the evening doing: reading and getting a jump on the next day’s work. No good would come of his children knowing he was off to check in on his apprentice in a guild of villains. It would only pointlessly change the way they looked at him, seeing a vision of who had been rather than who he was.

After all, it was no lie that Fornax was dead. He’d passed away the moment he was pulled from his cell and shown the picture of the newborn baby bearing his DNA. From that moment on, only Ivan had remained.

## Chapter 25

The afternoon sun sank further toward the horizon as Beverly finished clawing her way through their fourth gold-cored robot. At this point it was almost—*almost*—easy. Despite his injuries, Lance hadn't been bluffing about his ability to keep summoning and controlling bugs; not only had this been helpful in scouting, hunting had also become much easier with his ability to send clouds of bugs as bait to draw their adversaries in. After a quick run to the cave for some supplies to at least bring him halfway back to life, the young man had sent scouts across the sky in search of more robots. Shortly thereafter, a gold-cored arrived to take them down. Tori ambushed the robot in fire-form alongside a green-dragon Beverly; their mechanical opponent barely had the chance to throw up an energy shield that hissed and crackled as Beverly's claws cut through it. Her hands were bloody as it fell to the ground, but by the time the robot was in pieces, her wounds had healed. It seemed the green dragon really could take quite a bit of punishment.

"And this makes four." Tori pointed to the gold core, which Beverly quickly scooped up, using her claws like pincers and slipping it into the pouch on her expanded uniform. "Though, Lance, you're only getting a third of the ones you help bring down."

"Tell you what, why don't you just go ahead and keep my share too?" Lance said. He pulled himself slowly up from behind the rocks where he'd been hiding, his swarm replaced by an actual crutch Tori had fastened out of leftover parts from their salvaged silver-cored parts.

"You helped us destroy it," Tori reminded him.

"Sure, but you helped bandage my leg and gave me food and water. Never a good idea to overextend one's position in a deal. I'm lending aid as thanks for you two helping me survive this long, and hopefully until the end of the trial." Lance looked up at the dipping sun, taking in the splendor as its light danced across the mesas. "And seeing how much assistance I'll

need getting back, let's just say I feel more comfortable trading my help for yours rather than getting greedy."

"He's smarter than he looks," Beverly noted, the last of her dragon-self slipping away.

"To be fair, given my size and appearance, that's a pretty low bar." Lance shrugged his muscular shoulders and smiled with the sort of willful innocence that really had no place on an apprentice of the villains' guild. "But I am smart enough to know we're starting to get near the end of our time. We can try and hunt one more if you want, though I'd be surprised if getting back is really going to be as easy as just walking over."

"Four golds are enough for me," Tori said, turning her fiery head to Beverly, who nodded as well.

"Plenty enough to win, especially the way we're doing it. I'm all for playing it smart and getting back to the meeting point." To illustrate the point, she shifted back to her green dragon-form and walked over to Lance, lifting him from the ground as if he weighed no more than a few pounds and cradling him in her massive arms.

"Win or lose, I cannot imagine Arachno Bro isn't going to give me shit for this," Lance sighed from the crook of Beverly's arm. "Still beats not coming back at all, though."

"You can say that again." Tori turned back to full human-form, something she'd tried to avoid any more than necessary around Lance, and pushed aside a small set of rocks near the wall where she'd stashed her cannon. Turning it over carefully in her hands, she slowly made her way back across the mesa and held it out to Lance. "Here, I want you to hold this."

"Isn't that what the sling is for?" Lance pointed to the twisted fabric around Beverly's back, now largely empty except for the lone scroll resting inside.

"She can't carry us both, and I can't hold this when I'm in flame mode. If something gets the jump on us, you can still shoot, so you get tasked with holding it. Just remember: you only have one shot, and if you

use it on either of us, the other will make you regret it.” Tori shook the cannon once, moving it a few inches closer to the injured man in the dragon’s arms.

“Trust me, there is no gain in me taking a shot at either of you. But if something attacks, I’ll be ready.” Lance reached out and wrapped a meaty hand around the cannon, clutching it carefully against his pecs.

“Good. And don’t miss. Like I said, one shot left,” Tori reminded him.

“Think there will be trouble?” Beverly growled.

“Look at who we’re dealing with. The question isn’t *if* there will be trouble, it’s *how much* we’re about to step into.” Tori’s form grew blurry as she once more morphed to flame then pushed herself gently into the air with her controlled blasts. “Lance, keep your bugs on alert. I’ll try and scout as best I can. Beverly, if we get caught off guard, scatter first, then regroup.”

“Let’s finish strong.” Beverly’s gravelly voice echoed off the mesas as the three apprentices started on the final leg of their trial: the journey back to the start.

\* \* \*

The platinum timer ticked away steadily, shedding seconds as the time for the final confrontation drew closer. In Xelas’s room, the cheerful atmosphere had subsided significantly as each spectator watched the screens with more rapt attention than they had before. As veteran members of the guild, they knew that everything in the previous few days had merely been sport and spectacle, a way to test the mettle of each apprentice as well as entertain the watching guild. What was coming was the true test, their actual trial.

Of everyone present, no one was more nervous than Thuggernaut. While the others had met and enjoyed some of the rookies one on one, he was the only person present with a vested interest in seeing one make it back alive. Beverly was strong and had a good head on her shoulders, but she was still green. He could only hope that the last few days were enough to teach her that she wasn’t invincible. If she didn’t think through what was

about to happen, it could cost her more than spare change and bragging rights.

As he watched worriedly, Johnny laid a hand on the massive man's shoulder.

"Relax. She's a good one, and Ivan's kid has solid instincts. Add in that they've got the insect guy's powers, and those three have a real shot at making it."

"We've seen others with shots make bad choices," Thuggernaut replied, eyes unwavering from the screen.

"Maybe so, but none of them had you as a teacher. You know Beverly better than anyone here, and I've got no doubt you prepped her for this as much as you could. Now it's time to have some faith." Johnny leaned forward, nodding to the ticking clock with highlighted platinum numbers. "They can do it. And hey, you'll win a few bucks in the process."

"There's that classic Johnny way of navigating a moment," Xelas said. "But he's right. Those two are kicking ass, and adding in Lance only makes the group stronger. If anyone should be crapping themselves right now, it's Balaam. His apprentice hasn't exactly been going strong since the golds came out."

"Warren got one," Gork reminded them. He'd managed it after a morning of recovery, and while the effort was impressive, especially since he'd done it solo, it was still far too little to close the gap between him and the others.

"And if that were the real test, he'd be looking great. As it is, he has to know he's behind, and with only a few minutes left until the big game enters the field, the kid might be desperate enough to try something stupid." Xelas glanced at the clock, even though she was perfectly able to keep track of the time on her own. There was something a touch more dramatic, more human, about watching the tool with the others.

"Good or bad, looks like we're about to see how things are going." Johnny gestured at the screen where Tori, Beverly, and Lance were nearing the drop-off site. Tori blasted a few copper-cored drones out of the air,



seemingly clearing out the area. Of course, she didn't know what was still waiting. After all, there were still twenty minutes until sunset.

But more importantly, there were ten minutes left on the digital clock with platinum numbers.

\* \* \*

"That was actually pretty easy," Tori said as the last of the copper-cored drones fell to the ground in fiery scraps. From behind her, a loud, pronounced groan filled the air.

"You just had to say that, didn't you? Haven't you ever heard of a jinx?" Lance was propped against a pile of rocks, sonic cannon still in his hand, while Beverly rested nearby. She seemed intent on staying in dragon-form until they were safely out of the desert, a precaution that no one questioned the validity of.

"There's no such thing as a jinx."

"Says the lady who is made of living fire, to the boy that can summon swarms of insects, who is sitting next to the woman that turns into a massive dragon creature through what I'm assuming has to be magic," Lance countered.

"Fine, jinxes are real, but you don't activate them just by commenting on the fact that we weren't attacked much on way over," Tori replied.

"That probably depends on the jinx." Beverly's stout neck swiveled as she craned her head around to sight any incoming threats. Above them, the sun was dipping deeper toward the horizon. By their best guesses, sunset was likely only a half-hour away at the most. "You know, if it was a trap."

"Who would, or could, lay a trap for us that was triggered by us talking about the fact that we didn't get ambushed by robots on our way to a meeting place?" Tori demanded.

"Well, we do know that Warren uses magic," Lance pointed out, grinning despite the subject matter.

With a fiery huff, Tori lifted off into the sky to help Beverly scout. Buzzing overhead was Lance's cloud of gathered insects, a swarm that steered clear of the burning woman as she pushed herself free of gravity's tireless clutches. She rose partly to get away from the conversation and partly to sweep the area from a new vantage point, but mostly because she didn't know when her next chance to fly would be. Ivan was a good teacher, and despite his demeanor, she suspected he cared about her, but he wasn't big on getting her much practical training. Now that she'd finally pushed herself enough to learn she could leave the ground, it was an experience she wanted to repeat as often as possible.

Tori's annoyance was the only reason she was in a high enough position to see the movement. While Lance's bugs and Beverly's eyes scanned the sky, Tori happened to glance down at her fellow apprentices just in time to catch the shifting sand that was moving toward them. Something was burrowing beneath the surface, on a course directly for Lance and Beverly, who were just standing around unaware. With no time to think, Tori hurled a fireball just to the right of them, scorching the dry desert sand and immediately grabbing the pair's attention.

"Ruuuuuun!" Tori screeched the word, desperate to be heard through the great distance. Her flaming hands gestured wildly to the moving lump of sand, trying for all she was worth to get them to look over.

Mercifully, it was Beverly who trusted her enough to look away from the apparent attack. Her scaly eyes widened as she caught sight of the thing heading for them. Grabbing Lance by the shoulder, Beverly flung him through the air. He crashed in a groaning heap nearly forty feet away and immediately tried to right himself and figure out what had happened. As for the dragon, Beverly leapt backward, putting some distance between herself and the approaching enemy. Fast as her reactions had been, she still only missed the attack by a matter of inches.

A metallic pincer as long as green-dragon-Beverly was tall burst out of the sand. It sliced through the air, chopping the space where Beverly had been only seconds before. Red energy flickered between the two razor-sharp blades as they came together, filling the air with a sickening sizzle. As quickly as it appeared, the pincer sank back through the sand and rock, as

easy as a shark through water, vanishing completely save for the slight bump that gave away its movement.

It headed for Beverly, but she'd already taken a cue from Tori. Emerald green turned to pearly white as her scales shifted, arms turning to wings almost midair. Beverly took to the sky, rising upward with two powerful flaps before reorienting herself toward Lance.

The large, injured young man was no slouch at discerning a situation. While the sand robot had gone after Beverly, Lance had called every nearby insect he had to converge on his location. Together, hundreds of tiny wings were slowly bearing him away from the perilous position on the ground. It was clearly a struggle, though; he was less than four inches above the sand when the bump turned and headed toward his direction.

Strong, foot-like claws grabbed Lance by the shoulders and yanked him higher as Beverly beat her wings for all she was worth. While neither she nor the bugs could raise him quickly enough on their own, together they managed to get fifty feet off the ground by the time the sand bump would have been in striking range.

"What the hell is that?" Lance yelled, mostly for Tori's benefit since she was still flying over to join them.

"Platinum core, I guess," Tori replied. She eased off the fire blasts as she drew close, not wanting to careen into the swarm and kill any of the helpful bugs.

"Too easy," Beverly snorted. In this form, her words came out half-garbled. Evidently, the white dragons were less suited to speech than the green ones. "We can just fly away."

"We can, sure, but how many apprentices have flight powers?" Tori reminded her. "Though I'll give you that it does seem like a pretty serious design flaw, especially if it's meant to be as dangerous as the gold-cored ones."

"Um, you know how you didn't believe in jinxes?" Lance said, pointing to the sand below them.

From the depths beneath the desert, the robot began to rise. It was a massive beast, long as a line of buses and three times as big around. Out of its front extended a pair of sharp pincers, along with mandibles and dozens of glowing red eyes. Stretching up from the back was a long, metallic tail that whipped freely through the air with what appeared to be a glowing blade and some sort of cannon affixed to the end. Three thick legs extended from each side, half buried in the ground as it kept itself low. Along its back were dozens of turrets and guns, all of which were quickly rotating, aiming in the three apprentices' direction.

“Fuck me,” Tori said, taking in the instrument of death as it gazed at them with countless glowing, *targeting* eyes.

“Holy shit, it’s going to blast us. Scatter!”

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## Chapter 26

Tori blasted upward, racing away as fast as her flames would take her. Beverly let Lance go and went into a dive, zipping through the air with half-tucked wings. For a moment, Tori thought Beverly had taken the heartless route, but as the first shot ripped through the air, it became clear that dropping Lance had saved them both. He'd fallen faster than she could have moved while bearing him. Meanwhile, his insect swarm had slowed his fall and was steering him toward the relative cover on top of a nearby mesa.

The robot, some strange bastardization of a weapons depot and a scorpion, didn't take long to recover, reorienting its aim even as its targets tore through the sky in different directions. Beverly's grunts of pain reached Tori just as she felt a bolt of energy race through her own insubstantial leg. It didn't hurt, not exactly, but it definitely wasn't a pleasant experience. She knew from her experience with the sonic cannon that too much damage could push her back to human-form, and there was no reason to doubt these blasts' effect would be any different. Too much from them and she'd be a sitting duck. Strike that: a falling, flightless duck that would be finished off by the robot monster if the landing didn't kill her outright.

Forcing herself to turn up the intensity of her blasts, Tori cranked up the speed just in time to dodge the next volley of shots. This plan was no good; the damn thing could track and attack them all individually. As it was, they were simply treading water before they got shot down; counterattacking wasn't even on the table. They needed a moment to think, to plan, to recover. She glanced down at Lance, whose bugs had set him down on the mesa's top out of the massive thing's eyesight. Of course, given that it could somehow swim through rock and dirt, that wouldn't keep him, or any of them, safe for more than a few minutes.

Unless, of course, it had something else to attack.

Banking hard to the right, Tori sacrificed some of her precious altitude to drop within shouting distance of Lance. She couldn't chance

slowing down or changing direction, so she screamed, “Lance! The bugs! Send them out as one giant swarm right now. Make them stick close and draw its attention!” With that, she was past the mesa, only able to hope he’d heard her and that he trusted her enough to follow the seemingly crazy order.

Turning up her speed again, Tori raced through the sky, taking a few more bolts for her trouble. Pushing past the fear and first rumbling of pain, she raced onward, getting close to the white dragon that was ducking and dodging under the hail of fire.

“Get to the mesa!” Tori screamed the words as she and Beverly zipped past each other, the predicament of their situation not allowing for any more conversation than that. At first, she feared her ally hadn’t heard, but seconds later, Beverly took a sharp turn and flapped her way in the direction of the mesa.

A giant cloud of insects was slowly rising off of said mesa like buzzing steam from a boiling pot. Tori hurtled toward it, noting with some relief that the robot’s volley had begun attacking the bugs as well. She turned wide, passing behind the cloud of bugs before rocketing down, not so much landing on the mesa as crashing into it, her fire-body spreading like a dropped egg before reforming itself.

Getting up from the ground, Tori turned human and checked the sky. Beverly was coming in for a landing a few feet away, and the cloud of insects still seemed to be taking the endless onslaught, both of which meant they still had a fighting chance of living through this.

“Lance, you can see through the bugs, right? Is that robot moving or just attacking?”

“Hang on.” Lance closed his eyes for several seconds, long enough that Beverly landed with a mighty *whump* nearby before they snapped open again. “Just attacking. Do you think it doesn’t know we’re here?”

Tori quickly shook her head. “It’s a robot, running on programming. This one seems to seek out targets and engage them. I think as long as it has some target to fight, that protocol wins out over chasing other ones. At

least, that's what I was hoping when I noticed it didn't try to come after you after you left its line of sight."

"Great, so we use the bugs to keep it distracted then run by once the doorway opens?" Beverly had shifted to her green form. The half-dozen wounds on her arms and legs began to heal before Tori and Lance's eyes as the dragon-woman limped over.

"No. It has no problem targeting multiple enemies at once, as we just saw," Tori told her. "The bugs will buy us a few minutes, maybe, but the minute we step off of here, we're right back in the fight. Assuming we can wait it out until the doorway opens, we just have to think of a way to get past it."

"You don't want to try and take the thing out?" Lance asked.

"Too strong. Maybe with a full day to hunt it and learn its weaknesses, we could have given it a shot, but as things stand, I think we need to focus on surviving." Tori looked between the others, carefully checking each of their expressions. "Unless one of you knows of a way we can beat it."

"I'm trying to figure out how we'll survive even getting past it," Beverly replied.

"I'm on board with running, I just expected one of us to be more gung-ho about taking it down," Lance said.

"Nope, pretty sure we all want to not die. If that's even on the table." Tori moved slightly nearer to the edge of the mesa's cliff where she could look down on the landscape below. The cliff face where the portal would open was a few feet behind the wildly flailing tail that whipped through the air. No way around it; they'd have to pass the robot to make it out.

"Beverly, I hate to say this, but I think you need to get the scroll out."

"Whoa now, I told you I don't know what it does," Beverly said, turning to face Tori so quickly that her claws left marks in the rock beneath them. "The most I could figure out was how to activate the thing."

“Which is why we agreed it should probably be saved for an emergency,” Tori said. “Maybe we’re getting different reads on the situation, but this feels a lot like an emergency to me. As it stands, I’ve got no idea how we’re going to get past that robot. We need to change something, because this is not a good situation for us.”

“And what if it impairs me?” Beverly suggested. “If it’s a trap, then we’re even more screwed.”

“At this point, the degree in which we’re screwed is largely academic. We can only die once. And besides, everything we found in the caches—*everything*—was helpful. If there was ever a time to trust a mysterious magical scroll, this is probably it.” Tori glanced back at the area where the doorway would appear. She thought she caught the slightest waver on the earthen surface but dismissed it as a heat shimmer.

Grumbling under her breath, Beverly reverted to her human-form and pulled the sling free from over her shoulder. With a few motions, she unwound it and produced the scroll, which looked a bit beaten around the edges but otherwise no worse for the wear. Carefully, she unrolled the item, laying the parchment flat against the mesa’s rough surface, until a single circular symbol at the bottom was exposed. With a slight exertion, Beverly turned her left hand’s fingernails into sharp claws and pricked herself on her right thumb. As the red bead swelled atop her pierced flesh, she looked up at Tori once more.

“You sure about this?”

“Not even a little bit, but if you have a better plan, I’m open to hearing it.”

Beverly gave her answer by pressing her thumb into the small circle at the bottom of the scroll. “Commence,” she said, her words barely above a whisper.

Immediately, the symbol began to glow, the parchment turning into golden light and weaving itself around Beverly’s arm, working its way upward until it reached the magical tattoo etched around her neck. As soon as the two sources met, they exploded outward, completely engulfing Beverly and forcing the others to cover their eyes.



When the light finally cleared and Tori blinked away the last of the static-like spots from her eyes, a wide grin split her face as she took in what stood before her. Lance chuckled as well, and for the first time since they'd arrived on it, the mood atop the mesa turned hopeful.

"Yeah," Tori said, taking in Beverly's altered form. "I think we can work with this."

\* \* \*

Ivan stood positioned in a line with Thuggernaut, Arachno Bro, and Balaam, all four men staring at the wall where Tunnel Vision was about to open a doorway through space. Doctor Mechaniacal was in front of them, counting down the seconds until it was time to give the apprentices a way back. Only their mentors were allowed to be present for their return, a precaution meant to make the apprentices feel safe as well as ensure no staff were harmed in the retrieval process. These four were more than capable of handling anything a simple robot threw their way.

"Gentleman, in a few moments I am going to open the doorway. I want to remind you that once I do, it is prohibited by guild law for you to interfere with what lays beyond. Whether it be to help your own apprentice or hinder another, your influence can be nothing more than the training you imparted to them previously. I trust there are no objections?" Doctor Mechaniacal made a point of turning his helmet since his eyes were obscured, making sure each guild member knew he was looking at them. When no one replied, the helmet turned to Tunnel Vision with a curt nod.

"Do it."

As the wall before them began to shimmer, Thuggernaut leaned in and whispered to Ivan, "Nervous?"

"More than I expected. You?"

"Same." Thuggernaut paused, checking to make sure the portal wasn't open yet. "When Doctor Mechaniacal came to get me, they'd just released the platinum robot. I didn't get to see any of the fight."

"You know that isn't really—"

“I know. Still, have to keep up appearances,” Thuggernaut said.

“Just checking. At least they made it this far, and from what you said, they took down a few golds in the process. I wasn’t expecting them to do quite this well,” Ivan admitted.

“It’s an interesting group, full of surprises. I never thought ours would pair up, or that AB’s would join them later. Kids today. You can never tell what they’re going to do.”

Thuggernaut’s voice faded away as the wall in front of them turned transparent and then opened to a hot desert landscape. Initially, all they could see was the massive tail whipping about from the robot’s rear, but almost immediately a new sight caught their attention. Even the veteran council members found themselves slightly taken aback.

“Full of surprises, indeed,” Ivan chuckled.

\* \* \*

It was not a subtle plan. Given what the scroll had done to Beverly and the goal set before them, it would have taken someone with a mind far greater than any of the three gathered to work any sense of covertness into the tactics available. Recognizing that limitation from the outset, they didn’t bother to try. Instead, they opted for a strategy that put Beverly’s temporarily-altered state to good use. All things considered, the plan wasn’t a bad one. But it was literally as subtle as a giant green dragon barreling through the desert with an insect summoner and a fire-conjuring woman clinging to its back.

The scroll, as it turned out, increased the size of its user tremendously. Tori marveled at the massive limbs tearing through the sand as Beverly charged the scorpion-like robot head-on. In the back of her mind, Tori knew that Beverly’s limbs should be insufficient to support her new weight, that the enlarged woman should have been immobile. Yet science seemed to have taken the day off as the twice-transformed woman raced across the sand. Magic played by its own rules, and Tori was beginning to understand why so few people could straddle the scientific and the arcane.

“Are you okay?” Lance asked, yelling from his position on Beverly’s back. He and Tori could both hear the shots striking her scaly hide, but they didn’t seem to even register with Beverly, let alone slow her down.

“Can barely feel them.” Her voice shook loose debris from the nearby mesas as they raced past them. Tori could actually feel the sonic waves shake her too-human body as it worked to hang on. Fire-form would be safer, but she needed a good grip if she wanted to catch a ride.

Tori chanced a glance over the shoulder she was tucked behind. Not only were they close to their goal, but that the doorway had actually opened. Tori could make out a few figures just beyond the cliff’s entrance—no doubt Doctor Mechaniacal and some helpers to welcome them back or collect their remains. It was only a little farther, given Beverly’s pace, but to get there, they’d have to pass directly by the robot. It clacked its pincers in anticipation, and the tail that had been whipping wildly about halted, twisting itself around so it was pointed directly at the approaching dragon. Acting more on instinct than logic, Tori lifted herself up, right next to Beverly’s ear, and screamed as loud as she could.

*“Get down!”*

The giant dragon had barely thrown herself to the ground before the massive red beam of energy shot overhead, sizzling through the air where Beverly had been only seconds before. Scrambling to get up lest she make an easy target, Beverly still took a minute to twist her head around and stare at Tori with a gigantic eyeball. Though she didn’t speak, the implied question was evident.

“The last two models had cannons. Seemed like a good chance this one would too.”

Beverly let out a huff and hurried forward, eager to get moving again. If the tail needed to recharge, there was a good chance she might be able to get past before it succeeded. If it didn’t... well, they were probably screwed no matter what she did.

Mercifully, a second blast didn’t follow the first, and Beverly raced forward until she was nearly within striking distance of the scorpion-bot.

“Laaaaance,” Tori called, noting that they were getting closer than she wanted to be.

“Give me a damn second to line this up. You’re the one who made me hold the gun with only one bullet.” Lance was propping himself over Beverly’s shoulder, one hand holding the gun as it rested on her scales and one clinging on to her miraculously-expanded uniform for dear life. He took a deep breath, drawing as tight a bead as he could, and gently pressed his finger against the trigger. “Firing in three!”

“Heard!” Tori raised herself slightly, fireballs forming at the ends of each of her hands. There was no telling how much of a window Lance would be able to open up, if any. She had to do as much as possible with whatever chance they were given.

True to his word, three seconds later, a familiar boom rang through the air as Lance fired the final round of the sonic cannon. When the plan had been hurriedly conceived atop the mesa, there was ample debate about what he should aim for. A leg might knock the creature off balance, but taking down a pincer would remove half the melee threat. Ultimately it was Beverly, the only one among them who knew what it was like to be a powerful, armored creature, who told Lance where his shot would count the most.

The blast of sonic energy tore forward, smashing directly into the scorpion robot’s dozen or so glowing red eyes. It let out a high-pitched screech. That was all Tori needed to commence her own attack. Fiery bolts burst forth from her hands, scorching across its already wounded eyes as the scorpion robot scrambled to recover. While Tori doused its eyes in fire, Beverly swung wide, veering around the pincers as she made a run for the doorway. Within seconds, Tori’s angle of attack was gone, the eyes shielded from view as Beverly passed the metal monster’s legs. She returned her focus to the act of hanging on with all her might. The time for doing damage was over; now they could only hope it had been enough.

Hurtling forward, Beverly quickly closed the gap between herself and the doorway. The robot, much to their relief, didn’t try to turn around and catch her as she ran past. That relief was cut short when Tori realized

the tail was raised carefully overhead, tracking their movements as a familiar red energy began to glow from deep within the cannon's depths.

"Round two is coming!" Lance hollered, having noticed the same ominous glow as Tori. Beverly let out a snort of awareness but said nothing. Words would be wasted at this point. The cannon would be firing from point blank range if it got its shot off. They either made it through the door or died in the charge. No one had any tricks left up their sleeves.

Pumping her legs with all her considerable might, Beverly took three more steps forward then vaulted into a horizontal leap toward the doorway. Hands extended forward like she was sliding for home, it was clear that in only a few seconds she was going to crash into the side of the cliff, since she was far too large to fit through the doorway.

"Release!"

A sharp pop, like a balloon bursting, filled the air as giant-dragon-Beverly vanished, leaving behind only the normally large one. Despite the change in size, her momentum was still going strong, sending her, Tori, and Lance forward like they'd been thrown from a catapult.

There was a moment of uncertainty among the figures awaiting them, followed by a hurried scramble to get out of the way as they realized the three apprentices had almost no control over where they'd be landing. Beverly smashed through a table that was filled with soft drinks and sandwiches; Lance felt a rib break as he crashed into, and then through, a chair; and Tori was whipped about through the air until she slammed back-first into the room's far wall.

Whether it was due to exhaustion or her focused effort on staying human, Tori's body didn't shift, in spite of the impact. Her breath fled her lungs and her eyes opened wide, terrified words trying to escape but with no air available to form them.

Since she was facing the doorway, Tori could see the glow of the robot's tail as it took aim directly at the room they were now all gathered in. Her hand shook as she pointed toward it, trying to make the others notice, but before anyone else's head so much as swiveled, the tail cannon fired directly at them.

Tori's eyes clamped shut as she waited for the wash of pain followed by what she presumed would be an infinity of nothingness. When neither came, she slowly allowed her lids to part and see how she'd survived. What greeted her wasn't particularly surprising, at least not given all she'd learned in her apprenticeship, but it was still damned impressive nonetheless.

Standing at the edge of the doorway, looking more bored than strained, stood Ivan. He'd raised a single hand, around which rotated a circle of runes. The massive blast of energy, so much more powerful at this close a range, burned harmlessly against his shield before flickering out and dying entirely.

Ivan, task handled, lowered his hand, pausing only to pop his knuckles. He turned to face his apprentice. He cleared his throat and took one quick glance over his shoulder where the angry giant robot stormed across the desert before addressing Tori.

"That was... satisfactory."

## Chapter 27

“Kiss my ass, ‘satisfactory,’ that was fuckin’ awesome!” Arachno Bro raised a hairy arm and slapped into a high-five with Lance, lifting the muscular young man off the floor as though he weighed nothing more than a forgotten dream. Thuggernaut walked over to Beverly, who was already scrambling up by the time he reached her. Tori and Ivan’s gaze never left each other as she pulled herself back to her feet, the spasming in her lungs finally under control.

“I think you mean dangerous, unnecessary, and very poorly thought out,” Balaam said, somehow managing to look bored despite the spectacle he’d just witnessed.

“Someone’s just grumpy that his apprentice didn’t make it back with the others,” Arachno Bro snickered.

“Actually, I used a rune and slipped in while they had the robot distracted.” Warren emerged from behind one of the larger pieces of shattered table where he’d been hiding, hurrying over to Balaam’s side.

“What a fine use of planning and tactics, as well as capitalizing on the flaws of the lesser.” Balaam patted Warren’s head as though he were a child, awkwardly ruffling the younger man’s hair.

“I wouldn’t go throwing around words like ‘lesser’ until we know who actually came in first.” Thuggernaut didn’t seem aggressive, but his tone was stern as he steered Beverly over toward the metal-suited man who was Doctor Mechanial. “Apprentice, present your winnings.”

Beverly’s hands were nearly back to human as they plunged into her pockets, coming out with four golden orbs, a half-dozen silver ones, and a handful or so of the coppers. Doctor Mechanial took the lot from her, and after holding them for several seconds, announced his count.

“Four thousand, eight hundred and twenty dollars’ worth of orbs. Quite impressive, Apprentice. Who would like to go next?” The orbs he

was holding seemed to vanish, though keen eyes could spot them rolling into a compartment located just above his wrist.

Warren was there before anyone could so much as speak, plunking down his orbs unceremoniously in Doctor Mechaniacal's now empty hands. This assessment was shorter, as it was clear even from a distance that Warren didn't have nearly as many orbs as Beverly.

"One thousand, four hundred and ninety dollars. Very good indeed, but as of now, you are in second place." Again the orbs vanished. As Warren trudged over to Balaam this time, the older man didn't look particularly happy with his apprentice's placing.

"I might as well get this over with," Lance announced, half-hobbling across the room and plunking a pocketful of orbs into the doctor's hands. There was plenty of copper and more than one silver, but not a gold in the lot was anywhere to be found.

"Six hundred and forty dollars," Doctor Mechaniacal announced. He refrained from commenting on the paltry sum as he and the rest of the room turned to Tori.

"Oh, yeah, I got nothing." Tori held up her hands to show they were empty. "I'll take the last spot. Bev is the big winner."

A snort, followed by boisterous laughter, filled the air, all coming from Balaam. "Well now, that is an interesting surprise. Looks like Pseudonym's puppy has as much killer spirit as her teacher. I can't say I ever recall anyone surviving the first trial and yet still coming back empty-handed. Truly, you *are* his pupil, aren't you?"

Despite all the work she'd been doing on keeping her power under control, Tori knew the air around her was heating up as she stared down the red-eyed jackass and his ear-to-ear grin. She didn't know which was more aggravating—him insulting Ivan or her. It sort of all got swirled together in the miasma of pissed off churning through her.

Tori's mouth was halfway open, her tongue already intent on telling Balaam to go fuck himself, when she felt Ivan's hand rest firmly on her shoulder.



“It seems you’re right, Balaam. Though since my apprentice did pass the trials of survival, cunning, and temptation, I’d say she showed great potential in this weekend’s activities. Not to mention she was the only one who took the reins and tried to lead. Prioritizing safety and survival over pocket change... no, I can see why you wouldn’t appreciate the value in an apprentice like that. Luckily enough, I do.”

Tori’s tongue fell silent as Ivan’s words drifted through the room. Balaam stared at Ivan with such unmasked hatred that, for a moment, she really thought the two of them were going to get into it right then and there. Given that Ivan had just displayed how powerful he still was in a *very* visible way, she didn’t imagine things going well for Balaam if they did come to a head.

Clearly he reached the same conclusion. Balaam turned on his heel, swirling his red-and-black robes as he did, and began to march upstairs with Warren in tow. “Come, my Apprentice. Let us celebrate the good work you did, as well as discuss the ways you might improve.”

Something in his inflection made Tori wince. She felt a kernel of pity for Warren as he was dragged up the stairs by his teacher. Could that have been her, if Ivan had passed on the task of being her mentor? No; from what he’d said, they likely would have simply killed her outright. At the time, she’d thought he was being dramatic just to keep in line, but over time, Tori had started to realize that there might be fates worse the one hanging over her head.

“Now that that unpleasantness has passed, I suggest you all celebrate,” Doctor Mechanialac informed them. “We’ll have some fresh food and drinks brought down; no need to worry about trashing the tables. It happens so often during these things that we’ve learned to keep extras on hand. Enjoy yourselves. You must be famished from your time out there. Your money will be put into your respective bank accounts on Monday, with the added bonus going to Thuggernaut’s apprentice for her exemplary performance.”

Doctor Mechanialac paused, walking over toward to the staircase that Balaam had ascended. Their teachers followed him, albeit a few steps behind. When the doctor reached the edge, he turned his helmet toward

them once more. “Your teachers will each discuss your performance with you one on one, making sure you understand the lessons presented. But today, you have passed a hurdle toward guild membership, and as such, your involvement in our world will increase. Next weekend you’ll understand what I mean. So take this time to rest and enjoy yourselves, deepen the friendship that has begun to bloom, and remember that not all obstacles can be overcome on one’s own. That is a lesson the capes taught us firsthand, and it’s a mistake this guild is dedicated to teaching you to avoid.”

With that, he headed up the stairs, Thuggernaut, Arachno Bro, and Pseudonym all close behind. As they stepped out the door, Arachno Bro closed it firmly behind them, and Doctor Mechanical let out a long, low sigh of relief.

“Whew; the kids are taken care of. Now everyone to my quarters for the real party! I’m already there, waiting.”

\* \* \*

While Lance and Beverly were no doubt predominantly grateful to be back in a room with air-conditioning, with Lance being especially thankful for the handful of pain killers he’d been given for his injuries, it was the table of real food that filled Tori with gratitude for being back in the civilized world. Grabbing a paper plate, she darted for one of the tables they hadn’t smashed and began piling it high with chips and sandwiches, even helping herself to a cold beer. After the ordeal they’d been through, she felt entitled to at least a little relaxation. Lance was only a few steps behind her, and Beverly quickly followed. None of them were on the verge of starving, but protein bars were a poor replacement for actual culinary creations.

Lance and Tori made it through two sandwiches and Beverly four before the eating slowed down enough for conversation to bubble up. At first, they talked about the insanity of their last robot opponent, all blown away by how strong it had been. This turned to a discussion of how they would have fought it if given enough time and preparation. Eventually, the discussion gave way to the same topic every new meta-human focused on sooner or later: their powers.

“I’ve been collecting bugs since I was a kid,” Lance said, somehow managing not to slur a single word despite the ceaseless stream of chips entering his mouth. “We lived out in the deep country, and there was only so much to do after chores were finished. My granddad taught me about them, helped me learn the ins and outs of catching and respecting bugs. I kept it up even after moving to the city, as best I could. On the night of that big storm, I was in the museum’s entomology exhibit when an old statue of a scarab started glowing. All I remember after that is a lot of buzzing, some loud noises, and then when I woke up, things were different.” Tipping back a beer of his own, Lance cleaned it out in a single gulp, and then reached for a new one.

“Probably magic then, like me,” Beverly surmised. “Did you get any weird scarab designs on your skin?”

“Not that I’m aware of, and no one mentioned it to me after I got checked out the next morning.” Lance popped the cap on his beer using only his thumb, a motion so fluid that Tori could only imagine how many times he’d done it. “But weirdly they don’t think it’s magic. Doesn’t give off the same vibes or whatever. The current leading theory is that it was some codex from an ancient civilization, but that’s far from proven.”

“Then I guess you’re stuck in a mystery as well, at least as far as where your powers come from. How about you, Tori? You told me yours came from an accident, care to elaborate a bit more?” Beverly’s tone was almost inhumanly polite as she pried into something that clearly wasn’t her business. It was a strange contrast to the gruff way she acted when channeling her dragon powers.

“There isn’t much to tell,” Tori replied. “It was a few years ago, when I first started to work on the plans for my meta-suit. The hardest part of those things is creating a power source, you know. Any idiot can slap a rocket pack on a localized shield generator, but producing enough juice to run it is a big problem.”

Beverly and Lance exchanged glances, as both were reasonably certain her idea of “any idiot” seemed to require someone with far more technical expertise than them.

“So I was trying to crack that part first; you know, why build a car frame if you can’t make an engine? Most inventors use a meta-element like blagrinite or setlium, but I wanted something more stable. Anyway, I had this idea about converting the organic life found all around us, germs and bacteria and the like, into energy via a chemical reaction. When I fired up my prototype, it turned out I’d made a few miscalculations. Overload, explosion, and poof: here I am.”

“A self-created meta. I respect that. There aren’t a whole lot of those out there,” Lance noted. “I tried to ask Warren how he got his powers, but that guy apparently talks no more than he absolutely has to.”

“Somehow that doesn’t surprise me,” Tori said. She wasn’t sure how to feel about Warren. Sure, he seemed like a dick, but with Balaam as his teacher, it might be more reactionary and protective than malicious.

“I have to ask, did you ever figure out a way to power your meta-suit after that first failure?” Beverly had finished her plate of food and was absorbed in the conversation, leaning forward to carefully study the expressions of her fellow apprentices. Tori got the feeling it had been a while since Beverly was able to relax. Probably since the night she first turned into a massive dragon, if Tori were to place a bet.

“Well, yeah. I mean, my prototype didn’t exactly go as planned, but it did give me my power source.” Placing her own plate on the ground, Tori allowed her head and hand to engulf in fire, staring at Lance and Beverly as she did. “Fire’s not the most efficient energy out there, but since I never run dry, it should still work fine for my purposes.”

“Damn... you’re going to use yourself as a battery.” Lance took another long draw from his beer and nodded with approval. “That’s smart. Kind of weird, and definitely outside the box, but smart. Starting to see why the guild thinks you’re the one for us to beat.”

“Maybe I was before, but as of now, Beverly is the one who cleaned house at the trials. I came in fourth,” Tori pointed out.

“If I didn’t know better, and I’m not sure I do, I’d think you planned it that way to get some of the pressure off you,” Beverly said. Her tone was gentle, but a glint of suspicion twinkled in her eye.

Tori chuckled, turned off her flames, and picked her food back up. “I wish I could claim to have thought that far ahead. I might be—okay, I *am*—brilliant when it comes to electronics and mechanical stuff, but I’m awful at planning or scheming. I was basically flying by the seat of my pants out there, just like you two.”

“My cynical side wants to doubt you, but it’s pretty hard seeing as I was flying right there alongside you,” Beverly admitted. “Though part of me wishes you were a schemer. It would be nice to believe one of us has this all in hand. That might have been all the flying my pants can take.”

“Let’s just hope all our pants last for the rest of training,” Lance said. He lifted his beer up slowly, and after a minute, Tori figured out what he was doing. She tapped the glass of her bottle against his with a soft “clink.” Moments later, Beverly joined their toast with the side of her soda can.

“To the apprentices.” Lance’s voice was subdued for a change, the sudden touch of gravity in his words making him seem far less jovial. “May we all become the people we want to be.”

Everyone took a long drink, contemplating Lance’s words and thinking about how much still lay ahead of them.

\* \* \*

Like all parties held by the villains’ guild, the one following the apprentices’ first trial was filled with fine food, excellent liquor, and an endless sea of reminiscing. Soon it would turn to boasting, both about feats accomplished and of ones that would have been so, had things been different. Ivan never minded the boasting, even if he never saw fit to take part. He was fine with others reliving what they considered to be their glory days, riding the high of their previous adventures. If it kept them satisfied and obeying the code, he didn’t care if they spent all day, every day bragging about what they’d done.

Not minding it wasn’t the same as enjoying it, however. Shortly after they arrived at Doctor Mechanical’s quarters, Wade’s shock of copper hair visible even as the Doctor Mechanical suit walked itself into a power station to recharge, Ivan piled up a plate with decadent food and did his best

to project an unapproachable air. This had nothing to do with magic or his powers; it was a skill that involved lots of vacant stares, frowning, and pretending not to see people when they waved at him. He'd developed it over the years and was quite proud of how effective it was. Sadly, some of his guildmates were simply immune to his talents, even when his frown was set the deepest.

"No cash, but your girl put on a hell of a show." Xelas plopped into a chair next to him, or at least pretended to. Had she actually dropped the full weight of her metal body on the chair, it would have been in splinters; Xelas was well-practiced at appearing to bound about as easily as any normal human.

Morgana arrived a few steps behind Xelas, settling down into her seat with a natural grace. "She did seem skilled at making them work as a team." Morgana had ignored the food, instead choosing to help herself to the bottles of wine Wade had set out. Each was worth thousands of dollars, and they were for most of the guests to avail themselves of. Wade had but one rule when it came to expensive wine: only those who would appreciate it were allowed to drink it. Curiously, no one knew what would happen if that rule was broken, as it had yet to come up. Few in the guild had the power to disobey Doctor Mechanical, and of those that did, none had the inclination.

Ivan slowly set down the small fork he'd been using to spear escargot. "Your congratulations are appreciated but would be better directed toward my apprentice. She earned her own glory this weekend."

"Ah, but we didn't come by to congratulate; we came by to give fair warning." Xelas's ever-present, playful smile deepened, a sight which pushed her toward the uncanny valley and often made those she spoke with uncomfortable. "Morgana and I have been talking it over, and I think the council ladies are going to take the new gals out on a test drive."

"Nothing unseemly," Morgana assured him. "Just a little meet-and-greet, since Thuggernaut's apprentice didn't get to sit in on a council session like yours did. Plus, we thought it might be fun to get to know them. A girls' night out, if you will."

Looking back and forth between the two women, Ivan picked his fork back up and speared a fresh snail. “Is anything I say going to change this?”

“You could fight us if you reaaaaaaaally wanted to, but is it worth the effort?” Xelas asked, leaning back slightly in her chair. “Besides, you know talking with council members is good for newbies. We can give perspective, help them make connections, and generally get them more comfortable.”

“Your idea of comfortable is what I’m worried about.” Ivan pointed at Morgana with his fork and the butter-coated morsel at the end of it. “Are you going to be in charge of this?”

“Would Doc let us do it otherwise?” Morgana shot back.

“Fair point. Then I suppose I have no objections, so long as I can have enough warning to account for it in her training schedule. Also—and I feel this should go without saying—don’t get too attached. One trial does not a full member make.”

“Come on. We’re not the ones who’re rookies. We know the deal.” Xelas allowed her chair to hit the ground and rose fluidly to her feet. “I’ll get you a date as soon as we talk to Thuggernaut. In fact, I see the big man over there by Johnny. Morgana, let’s hustle.”

“Thanks for being a good sport,” Morgana said, smiling briefly at Ivan before Xelas half hauled her across the room.

Ivan popped the escargot into his mouth as he watched them go. Xelas was as brilliant as she was crazy—and the mechanical maiden was easily mad as a hatter—but she knew which lines were suggestions and which not to cross. Furthermore, Morgana was probably the most responsible person on the council, next to Wade, and if Gork was going too, then that would only make things easier. All in all, it likely would be an excellent opportunity for Tori to make connections and learn from experience.

In fact, it was so good he was a bit surprised there wasn’t an effort underway to have a similar night with the male trainees. A moment’s

consideration and Ivan realized that would mean putting the apprentices around himself and Balaam with only Wade as a buffer. No wonder that idea hadn't been suggested. One night of that would be enough to make even the most dedicated apprentice throw their next trial just to find the sweet release of death.

Maybe Johnny could put something together, though. Ivan decided to speak with him about it; after his meal was done, of course.

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## Chapter 28

“Drop me off here.” Tori pointed toward the coffee shop on the corner halfheartedly, her eyes drooping as she struggled to keep them open. In all the excitement and celebration of their victory the night before, it had completely slipped her mind that she had work in the morning. Ivan, however, had suffered from no such memory lapse. The heartless bastard had nearly dragged her out of her apartment, hustling her into the car with no concern for either her sleep-deprivation or mild hangover.

“There’s coffee in the office.” Ivan, despite having been out as late as Tori, looked just as ready for the day as he always did. She wasn’t sure if it was an aspect of his powers or a learned skill; all Tori knew in that moment was that she hated him for it.

“There’s cheap pisswater and non-dairy creamer in the office. My body will not accept any imitators today; only the real deal is going to get me moving.” Tori tapped her finger carefully on the car’s clock. “We’re still twenty minutes early, and the office is literally across the street. I’m on my time, and I’d like to spend it funneling caffeine down my throat so I don’t fall asleep at my desk.”

The traffic light changed, and Ivan pulled the car forward. Making a split-second decision, he eased over into a free parking spot and motioned to the door. “Don’t be late, and drink as much as you need to be functional. We’re coming up on quarterly reviews, so there’s a lot to get done.”

“Yeah, yeah, when isn’t there?” Tori popped the door open, unbuckled her seat belt, and slid out of the car before Ivan could change his mind. No sooner had the door shut than Ivan pulled back into the street, going all of thirty feet before taking the left turn into the company parking lot. While the sudden movement made her headache a bit worse, the fresh air filling her lungs helped her feel awake for the first time all morning.

Downtown Ridge City was a lovely place; the city went to great pains to make it that way. Carefully chosen trees were spaced out along the sidewalk, shading the dozens of corporate drones walking to their offices in

the early morning sunlight. All of them wore slacks, polos, or suits like Tori's, and despite the fact that it was Monday morning, some had even donned smiles as well. The good mood was so contagious that Tori allowed herself a slight smirk of her own as she pushed open the front door of Ridge City Grinders.

The place had cleaned up nicely since the night of the confluence, or what almost everyone in town thought of as 'the big-ass storm'. While Ridge City Grinders had been flooded and lost most of its windows, there had only been a short delay before it reopened. In a town with this many capes, collateral damage was bound to happen, and as a result, people were used to putting things back together. It certainly didn't hurt that the AHC often funded cleanup efforts after a big bout of destruction.

Tori slipped into line and quickly scanned the board to see what seemed good. With chains, she always knew what she wanted, but in local shops, she tried to explore the specialties. Nothing really caught her eye as the line moved briskly forward, and before she knew it, Tori had arrived at the counter with no idea what she wanted to order.

"Morning!" The perky barista had short bleached-white hair and the name "Chloe" emblazoned on her apron. She was easily the cheeriest person Tori could ever imagine meeting on a Monday, let alone encountering in real life. "What can I get for you?"

"I... uh... shit. I sort of blanked out. What do you recommend?" From over her shoulder, Tori could hear the passive-aggressive shuffling and sighs from the people in line. If she'd been in their position, she'd have done the same, but this was how things were, so they were going to have to deal with it. She needed her damn coffee.

"Well, if you're looking to really wake up, we do some of the best espresso in the entire town. Smooth and tasty but with enough kick to get your day off right." Chloe, at least, was unfazed by the grumpiness in the line behind Tori. Tori could only imagine putting up with pissy, under-caffeinated corporate drones all day. She'd probably light someone on fire before the end of her first shift.

"Sounds great. Give me four. To go, please."

Chloe's blue eyes widened so much that Tori could make out the lines of her contacts and the telltale stripes of her brown irises underneath. "Are you sure you want that much?"

"I've got a good tolerance. Four, to go, please. The name on the order is Tori." Tori whipped out the debit card tied to her meager bank account and scanned it through the register, pausing to key in a decent tip for the cheerful barista who hadn't gotten mad at her for holding up the line.

Less than five minutes later, another worker called her name and handed her a tall cup filled with hot brown liquid. Taking a tentative sip, Tori noted that it was scalding hot—not that such things bothered her—but also surprisingly delicious. Usually the espresso she got had an acrid, harsh taste, but this one was mellowed out. From the way her heart rate increased the moment the first drop hit her tongue, it still had the expected kick too.

Tori lifted her cup to Chloe as she headed out the door, and the blonde barista replied with a big smile and a wave. All in all, it was a pleasant start to a Monday. Tori headed toward the office feeling hopeful that just maybe this wouldn't be such a bad day after all.

\* \* \*

Unnoticed by Tori as she walked from Ridge City Grinders to her office building, a blue sedan sat in front of a recently-expired meter. Its occupants noted her approach to the building just as they'd taken down all the comings and goings for the last several weeks. Ten years earlier, such behaviors might have seemed suspicious, but these days, three men in suits typing away on laptops just looked like a group that was trying to finish up a presentation before it was due. No one walking through downtown spared them more than a passing glance, forgetting about the men inside almost as soon as the sedan faded from view.

"Has the girl ever stopped for coffee before?" The man in the driver seat watched Tori make her way briskly across the street, gleefully chugging a beverage that he had no idea would scorch the roof of anyone else's mouth.

"Not since we've been watching." This came from the thinner man on the passenger side. He held a laptop on his... well, lap, with a

spreadsheet program open. On it he noted the time Tori entered the building, next to a small note that she'd stopped for coffee, breaking her established pattern.

"Unexpected, but there's always going to be a few variables that are impossible to account for," Driver remarked. "On the whole, it looks like morning is still going to be our best window."

"Oh, come *on*, guys. Who does this kind of shit in the morning? Nighttime, that's when it'll look the coolest." These remarks came from the wide-shouldered man in the back seat who leaned forward and rested his elbows on either side of the center console. "We want to be taken seriously, don't we? We need to make sure this comes off as fucking sweet as possible."

Passenger punched in a few more keystrokes while Driver scanned the street, both of them doing their best to ignore Back Seat. Neither of them had been particularly happy about adding him to their plans, but there was no help for it. Annoying as he was, Back Seat was necessary if they wanted to succeed. After all, only an idiot went into an operation like this without a contingency plan for meta-humans. The damn things could hide in plain sight; anyone from the girl at the coffee shop to that nerdy red-headed programmer slipping in the building's side door could be one. It was impossible to tell, so the only sensible thing to do was to make sure they had one on hand.

"The slacking copper-top makes up the last of the early morning group," Passenger noted. "About fifteen people will be on the Vendallia Industries' floor for the next twenty minutes. After that, the rest of the staff arrives to barely make it in on time."

"So this is our window. Get in and get things secured while the number is small enough to deal with." Driver carefully rested his hands against the wheel, thinking all the possibilities through. "Any variations in the last week?"

"Aside from the coffee, only minor ones," Passenger confirmed. "This timeframe is going to be our best shot."

A loud groan came from behind them and both men resisted the urge to turn their heads. “Seriously? This early? Fine, whatever, but this isn’t going to impress anyone.” Back Seat removed his elbows and leaned back, his sizable frame barely contained by the sedan’s rear. “Should we just go do this thing, then?”

At last, Driver turned around to face the car’s third member, a scowl visible even behind the designer sunglasses on his face. “We are most certainly not going to ‘just do this thing,’ either today or when the time comes. This is a carefully planned, formulated strike, and under no circumstances will we burst in there without proper preparation. Now that we know the best time to work in, we’ll need to gather supplies, which will take—”

“About three days,” Passenger interjected.

“About three days.” Driver glanced away from Back Seat, staring at Passenger, who was still clacking away on his laptop. “Wait, really? Only three days?”

“I did most of the groundwork in advance. All that’s left is to make and fill the orders... about three days. Which is good; we want to work as soon as possible, while our data is still fresh. If we wait, things might change.”

“Huh.” Driver swung around to Back Seat, who was grinning from ear to ear. “Okay then, looks like we’ll be doing this in three days. Try to constrain yourself until then.”

“You’re the boss,” Back Seat replied, using a tone that made it clear that while his words might be technically true, neither he nor anyone else believed them.

Driver ignored it, turning back to the steering wheel and twisting the ignition key. With a quick change of gears, he sped off into the street, narrowly avoiding the parking attendant who’d been coming over to write them up for the expired meter.

\* \* \*

“Uuuuuuggggghhhhhh.” The half-grunted moan came from Tori’s lips as her head rested heavily on her desk. Her good mood and sense of optimism had both evaporated along with the caffeine high from her espresso. Several cups of the office coffee had allowed her to keep trudging along, but by the time she’d finally gotten enough time to eat lunch, she was seriously beginning to wonder if maybe it wouldn’t be better to torch the office and just deal with the guild’s retribution. The sole bright spot in her day had been getting the bank alert that Beverly had transferred over half of the weekend’s winnings.

What Ivan had failed to tell her about “quarterly review week” was that the workload quintupled as they prepared charts, reports, and endless graphs explaining what they’d spent the last three months doing, all while performing the actual work for which the department was responsible. Adding on to that were the interviews every employee had to go through where they ensured they’d hit all their targets and set new goals for the coming quarter. For most of the staff, those meetings were just one annoying hour. For management and management’s overworked assistant, they ate up more time than a watch-devouring goblin.

“And miles to go before you sleep.” Donald peered over from the slim wall that divided their desks and threw her a look of pity. He’d taken his own lunch hours before, as had most of the people not completely bogged down in the miasma that was quarterly reviews. “On the upside, they only make you do this once every three months, and it usually only lasts a week.”

“Oh no. Fuck that. Fuck a whole wet sloppy mess of that. Next quarter, I am at least not going to be dealing with the management side of this.” Tori lifted her head off the desk, bloodshot eyes brimming with determination. “If nothing else, I will be a regular employee and only have to deal with the simple side of things.”

“Well, that’ll be pretty easy to manage.” Donald reached over to her keyboard and struck a few keys, quickly pulling up the company’s home site. “Vendallia keeps an internal job board just for the employees to use. We’re supposed to choose career paths and work toward them, so this lets us see what’s available and what it takes to make it there; that way we can tailor our resume to fit it.”

“That’s surprisingly helpful,” Tori said, skimming through the listings at the top of the page. Most of them demanded more formal education than she had, though a few allowed for time at the company and the passing of skill tests in place of a degree.

“Training costs money and lowers efficiency,” Donald replied. “If they can keep everyone in-house instead of letting them learn skills and get recruited away, it works out better for the bottom line in the long-term. Nothing like dangling a carrot to keep us plodding along, you know?”

“Mmhmm.” Her eyes kept flitting through the jobs one by one. Management was out of the question—she did not want to deal with these reviews again, and besides, they all demanded at least five years with Vendallia before one could even apply. The tech jobs, on the other hand, were well within her skill-level. Heck, she’d likely have to pretend to be worse than she was just to avoid arousing suspicion.

Donald leaned back, putting himself more in his cubicle than hers. “I’m glad to see you’re thinking about staying. Be nice to still have a friendly face around, even after your internship is over.”

“Oh. Right.” Tori’s hand stopped, finger frozen just above the mouse. Right... this was supposed to be temporary. She was only working here because of Ivan. Her apprenticeship, and therefore her internship, would end when she made it into the guild. After that, she wasn’t required to work a regular job anymore. Granted, no one had told her what the other choices were, but she assumed they existed.

For the first time since Tori had been told she was in a “pass or die” situation, her mind turned to what would come after graduation. Could she work on her inventions in peace? Would she be required to participate in heists? Was there a crime quota? She’d been so focused on making it across the finish line, she’d never bothered to ask if the road on the other side was even paved.

Suddenly, the rest of the day’s meetings were no longer the most bothersome thing on her mind.

## Chapter 29

“A quota? Like, we make you mug so many people in a week? No, the guild doesn’t impose a mugging quota.”

Ivan set down Tori’s plate across from her, the pork loin still steaming as butter from the peas melted against its side. He lowered his own dish too, piled high with food that Tori had quickly learned only represented a fraction of what had been cooked. The man could eat, there was no question about that, and as he took his seat across from her at the dinner table, his fork was already in his hand to do precisely that.

“Obviously not a mugging quota. I just meant...” Tori waved her hand through the air in wide, vaguely circular motions. “I don’t know, some allotment of crime we had to fulfill. It is a guild of villains and criminals, after all.”

“No, it is a guild of people who do not always enjoy the confines of the law and who prefer to stay out of jail and the ground.” Ivan sighed then chewed a few bites of food before continuing. “Crimes are committed by members of the guild and organized on guild premises, but in case it has slipped your notice, the vast majority of your education has emphasized survival and not getting caught.”

“I’d say you talked more about the code than anything else,” Tori pointed out.

“What did you think I meant by ‘survival’?” Ivan countered.

Tori swallowed; though, to be fair, she had also taken a bite of peas, so it could have been necessity rather than reaction. Either way, Ivan trusted his point was made and decided to put her mind at ease.

“You’re going to learn the specifics this weekend, but essentially the guild functions as an organizer and approver of criminal plans. Someone comes up with an idea, puts together a proposal, runs it by those of us who have the experience to see any potential flaws, ideally receives approval, gathers a team, and then executes their job. At no point in that process is



anyone forced to pull capers against their will. We even have an entire department and seat at the council to represent all of those who choose to have no involvement with criminal activity whatsoever.”

“I sort of figured that was something you had to work your way into. Like, put in ten good years, you earn the right to retire,” Tori admitted.

“Not at all. In fact, many of those who make it into the guild immediately put themselves in my department. Remember, Tori, the goal of this organization is not to increase crime: it is to make sure crimes are committed in a way that keeps us protected. Choosing to do nothing doesn’t counter that philosophy, so it’s a perfectly valid choice.”

“I get it. I can opt to do jobs as long as I run them through the guild, or I can work a nine to five like you. The only thing I can’t do is break the code, right?”

Ivan smiled slightly, a rare accompaniment to dinner, and nodded. “That is the sum of it. Upon graduation, the path you choose is up to you, so long as you stay within the guidelines we’ve provided.”

“But I bet I’m going to have to pick up at least a little side work if I’m going to get the parts for my tech or pay off the loaners Doctor Mechaniacal put in the basement.” Tori mulled it over as she chewed her pork. Now that she knew she wouldn’t *have* to be a criminal, the idea wasn’t nearly as scary. In fact, snatching some extra cash from time to time might be a useful option to have. “Tell me more about how jobs work.”

“I think it can wait until this weekend. In some cases, it’s better to show than tell.” Ivan stood from the table, his plate miraculously clean, and headed for the kitchen. “Can I get you seconds on anything while I’m up?”

“Yeah, peas, please,” Tori called. The mysterious job-talk had her curious, but after weeks with Ivan, she’d learned that when he said no to something, it was fairly permanent. Besides, after the spectacle that had been put on over the last weekend, she probably would rather just see whatever they had planned. Thinking of jobs did raise another concern, however. As Ivan returned with his freshly filled plate along with a bowl of peas for her, she decided that since they were already talking about the future, she may as well push her luck.

“Am I allowed to keep working at Vendallia after my apprenticeship is over? Or is it just a temporary thing, like my living here, and as soon as we’re done I’m going to have to find some new job?”

Ivan stared across at her, his plate rattling slightly as he set it on the table. For a second, Tori couldn’t read his expression, and then she realized why. She’d caught Ivan by surprise, which meant he was making a face she rarely got to see.

“To be honest, it never occurred to me that you’d want to,” Ivan said at last. “Your work is fine, but you’ve never shown any interest in the company as a whole.”

“I work in a cubicle farm for a faceless corporation. How much interest were you expecting to see?”

“Right around the exact amount you’ve shown, hence why I assumed you’d want to move on when your time was done,” Ivan told her.

“Okay, I guess that’s a fair point.” Tori dragged her fork through the bowl of peas Ivan had brought out, trying to find the right way to phrase her curiosity. “I don’t love it there or anything, but maybe it’s not as bad as I’d thought. Well, except this week. This week is fucking awful. Overall, though, it’s not such a terrible place to be. And if I wanted to keep at it, maybe even apply for a real job where I made good money and got to use my brain, I just wanted to know if that was on the table.”

A slight clink filled the air as Ivan set his fork down, nicking the side of his plate in the process. “Tori Rivas is an employee of Vendallia Industries. Your identity is on file there. Your social security number. Your face on the badge. Tori Rivas, not my apprentice. Assuming your performance reviews are satisfactory and you don’t do anything to get fired, there’s nothing to stop you from staying with the company, regardless of role.” Ivan picked his silverware back up but held it gently in his hand, not yet turning it on the food that still remained.

“That is the benefit of having an identity outside your guild one. That is why I forced you to be an intern in the first place. You have a place in the real, normal world now, and it’s one that no one in the guild has the

right to take away from you. They only have power over Apprentice, not Tori.”

“Unless I fuck up and they kill me,” Tori added, eating a forkful of peas to punctuate the statement.

“In that case, I would say Apprentice had to die and Tori was unfortunate collateral damage. But you’ve made it this far despite what others might have thought. Perhaps you should continue thinking about your future, lest it blindsides you when the time comes. Oh, and pick a code name early on. Ever since Johnny slipped his through, we made the approval process more rigorous.”

Tori snorted in spite of herself and barely managed not to spit peas across the table.

\* \* \*

“Ren, my man, just the animal-human hybrid I was hoping to find.”

Apollo slipped a friendly arm part of the way around Ren Tanaka’s giant shoulders, somehow managing to hold on to his aura of authority even as he was dwarfed by the creature Ren had become. Scales had sprouted beneath his initial fur, and a long tail with a razor-sharp blade at the end swung freely from his rear. He’d also grown slightly, albeit more outward than upward as his already muscular, inhuman body easily packed on mass.

Around the break room, the other rookies shot them both dirty looks as Apollo led Ren into the hallway. In the past few weeks, it had become all too clear who the most powerful of the new recruits were, and the older capes hadn’t bothered to hide the favoritism the frontrunners were receiving. These were the top choices, the first draft, and they wanted to keep them all happy enough to stick around.

For his part, Ren ignored the mutterings and glares, even though he could hear their movements so well he could even hear their displeasure in the creaking of their bones and blood. Adapting to his new senses had been one of the hardest parts of the transition, but after Data Mine created a special chamber to cut him off from the world when he slept, the worst was over.

“Ren, it’s time we swing by the office of some people you’re going to love because they make sure everyone else loves you.” Apollo was as confident as ever as he guided the hulking giant through the spacious halls, made extra-large specifically for people like Ren. He beamed at everyone they passed, pearly white smile and golden glow both as intoxicating as ever. It was bullshit, obviously—no one was that cheery all of the time—but it was the sort of bullshit that was hard to call someone out on. There was no way to say a person was too cheerful without coming off as an asshole. Ren should know; he’d racked his brain trying to come up with a way.

“Where are we going?” Despite still having full use of his cognitive faculties (Ren was in fact starting to suspect that he’d gotten smarter), talking was still something of an ordeal. His tongue was wide and flat, not quite suited for making words as much as it was for cleaning his fur. But over the weeks he’d learned to manage basic communication, though every word took such focus and effort to pull out that these days he spoke briefly when he spoke at all.

“Why, right here!” Apollo let go of Ren’s shoulders and pulled open the door to a large conference room. Standing inside were a man and a woman wearing matching dark colors in their professional clothing who stood as soon as they saw Ren. It wasn’t a fearful leap. It was a respectful rising to acknowledge that he’d entered the room, and Ren found himself oddly appreciating it.

“Meet Jessica and Barney, the Alliance of Heroic Champions’ top image consultants,” Apollo explained quickly, shutting the door and slipping into a cushy leather chair. There was one next to him that was identical save for the fact that it was three times as large and no doubt heavily reinforced. Ren sat down in it as quietly as he could manage, sliding his bladed tail through a small slit in the back.

“And we are just thrilled to meet you,” Jessica said, a slight southern twang under her sophisticated voice. Ren wasn’t sure if anyone else could hear it or not; he was still working out just how different his senses had become.

“Sure are. Why, everyone we’ve met just tells us the best things about you.” Barney was the first person Ren had ever met whose wide smile and ample enthusiasm matched Apollo’s. He didn’t quite have the act down as well, though, and Ren could see the small ways it was already wearing on him. Hopefully that would at least mean this was a short meeting.

“See, Ren, since we all know you’ve got what it takes to make it here at the AHC, I thought we should get a jump on everything so that once it becomes official, you can be ready to go,” Apollo said. “And the first thing we have to nail down for any worthwhile superhero is their name.”

Jessica and Barney both nodded along as Barney pulled a stack of files from his briefcase. “Given your imposing looks, we felt it was important to find a name that captures the essence of who you are while also making you accessible to a family-friendly audience,” he told those around the table. “After several focus groups and some market testing, we got it down to a few.”

“First off was Chimera,” Jessica said, picking up smoothly where Barney left off. She snagged a paper and laid it down. The name and a graph of marketing data filled the page. “Now, technically there was already a Chimera back in the pre-AHC days. But since he died before any solid trademarks were filed and since chimeras are creatures of legend, we felt it would be an easy win, legally speaking. The problem is that Chimera doesn’t test very friendly, and it’s a bit on-the-nose given your powers.”

“After that, we were leaning toward Grendel, an obvious allusion to Beowulf and well within the public domain; however, after seeing the test scores, we decided that we could do better. We could get you something that the people loved.”

Ren could hear Barney’s heart speed up as he finished his sentence, followed by Jessica’s as she prepared to talk. This was the name they were really trying to sell him on; their bodies were giving away the nerves that their smiling faces masked. He wished they’d just hurry it up. Teeing up two toss-outs just to make him more receptive might be good for sales, but it was a pain in the ass to sit through.

“After going back to the drawing board, talking with some experts, and really poring through the people’s reactions, we finally found what we were looking for.” Jessica tossed down the paper, which, to her credit, did boast a graph showing far better numbers than either of the other two.

“Med-ley?” Ren asked, sounding out the word as he read it from the top of the page.

“That’s right, Medley. A mixture of many things, but in a way that’s harmonious,” Barney said. “I have to tell you, people really reacted well to that name. It made them feel good, safe, and as though the person sporting it was someone to be trusted.”

Both of them were staring at Ren now, fake smiles and eager eyes waiting to hear if they were going to have to spend more time on this kid who wasn’t even fully in the AHC yet. Next to them was Apollo, who Ren found impossible to read, grinning in his own more practiced way.

The name was fucking stupid; there was no way they didn’t know that. Ren looked like he’d escaped from a deranged zookeeper’s nightmare, so they were trying to pin the most milquetoast name possible on him to balance out his image. He could still say no if he wanted to. He could tell them to take a flying fuck at the moon, pack his shit, and be out the door. But then what? His old life, his old body, all of it was gone. Ren Tanaka was dead in every way that mattered. This was his new world, his new life. What did it matter that the name was stupid? If it made some kid he pulled out of harm’s way a little less scared, then that was worth it.

“Medley,” Ren said again, this time getting the word out in one go. “I like it.”

The wave of relief from Jessica and Barney was so tangible it nearly pushed Ren’s chair back from the table.

## Chapter 30

It was probably a good thing Ivan had forced Tori to get her sporadic heat bursts under control, because by the time Wednesday afternoon rolled around, she was so worn out and annoyed that half the office would have been suffering from heat stroke. As she marched down the dingily-carpeted hallway, a stack of files that it really would have made more sense to move digitally filling her hands, Tori kept focusing on not letting her frustration roll off her in palpable ways. Her morning espresso from Ridge City Grinders had already stayed hot in her hand much longer than it should have, so she was being extra careful.

“Delivery of more cr—stuff,” Tori announced, barely stopping herself as she remembered they were in the Vendallia offices, not at home or the guild. Ivan either didn’t notice the near slip or, most likely, chose to let it slide as he continued working on the small mountain of paperwork at his desk. He did pause his pen, but only long enough to motion to a free area on a filing cabinet where Tori could put the pages.

“And with this done, I am officially taking a coffee break.” Tori set the pages down carefully, all too aware of how much time had gone into getting them properly organized and unwilling to do such a tedious job over again.

“Try to keep it in the building, there’s still more to do.”

“Hey, how I take my fifteen minutes is up to me. If you insist on having me do all this junk, the least I can do for my tired body is fill it with caffeine that doesn’t taste like forgotten dumpster water,” Tori replied.

Ivan looked up from the pages and glared at her, then slowly shut his eyes in resignation. “Vendallia policy is that you can go off-site if you so desire, so long as you’re back at your station when the fifteen minutes are up, which I will check to ensure is the case.”

“Deal!” Tori spun on her heel and was halfway out of the office before Ivan’s voice called her back in.

“If I may ask, is the coffee over there really so much better than what we keep on hand?”

“As long as it’s not counting against my fifteen minutes, you can ask me anything you like, boss.” Tori stayed partway out the door, making it clear what her answer would be if she was talking through her break time. Ivan gave her a nod and motioned her back inside. She happily complied: any non-break time not spent working on quarterly reviews was fine by her.

“Yes, Mr. Gerhardt, the coffee over there is a lot better than what we stock. More varieties, more flavor, and just an all-around better product. The discount store barrel stuff they buy us here is probably great for the bottom line, but you can’t really expect it to compete with the real deal.”

Lowering his pen again, Ivan began scrawling something once more. For a second, Tori thought the meeting was over, but then Ivan ripped the sheet of paper off the notepad he’d been writing on and held it up.

“Take my company card and get me this order, please, along with whatever else you were going to get. Also, see if they do catering work, and if possible, grab a sheet with their prices and hours. I realize this will take longer than fifteen minutes, and as such, I won’t be counting the coffee run as your break time.” Ivan pulled his credit card out from his pocket and offered it to Tori along with the paper in his hand.

“What’s with the sudden interest in java?” Tori quickly grabbed both items as she spoke, not about to give him the chance to change his mind. Free coffee and an actual break when she returned? This was, sadly, going to be the highlight of her day.

“Everyone has been working hard for the quarterly reviews, and I’d like to thank my department with a treat on Friday to celebrate reaching the end of things. I was planning on just getting donuts, but there’s probably enough room in my discretionary budget to squeeze in some coffee too. Assuming it’s as good as you say it is, I think it will do wonders to help lift people’s spirits.”

“Don’t worry about that. I’ll have Chloe make sure to hook you up with the good stuff.”



Before Ivan could point out that he actually wanted to taste what their average product was like, Tori was out the door, this time determined to get clear before he could stop her. Ivan stared at the empty door for several seconds then turned his attention to the massive pile of work still looming before him. He really hoped the coffee turned out to be worthwhile. Tori wasn't the only one who could use a pick-me-up today.

\* \* \*

Tori took her time heading across the street to Ridge City Grinders, a stark contrast to the brisk pace she would have used if she were on her actual break time. Her mind was filled with thoughts of wonderful caffeine and curiosity over what the weekend would hold when she was back at the guild. No matter how torturous it might be, there was no way it could compete with quarterly reviews. That much was obvious.

She was so distracted by her musings that Tori didn't notice the three men sitting in a sedan with open Chinese food containers on the dash, as they appeared to be nothing more than workers enjoying a quick lunch. Had she paid more attention, it might have struck her that this car had been parked around the area an awful lot.

"That Mexican gal sure does drink a lot of coffee," Back Seat noted as they watched Tori head in and greet Chloe with a wave.

"Pretty sure the term is Hispanic," Driver corrected, barely looking up from his container of noodles and pork.

"Actually, I believe in recent years the more acceptable phrase has shifted to Latino or Latina, depending on the person's gender," Passenger pointed out. "Though Dirk would actually be in the right with Mexican, assuming he had knowledge that she was from Mexico."

"Hey, I've got a question: why do either of you give a shit?" Dirk, the man previously known as Back Seat, laid his sizable arms on the seats of his companions, making his weight felt so he couldn't be ignored.

"Saying it wrong just sounds ignorant. We might be robbers, but we're not assholes. Do you want to be like that cape who flies around in the mechanical Klan suit?" Driver said.

“Shit, man, I was just asking. Don’t put me in the same league as the Whitest Knight.” Dirk pulled away and rested his back against the rear of the seat, causing the car’s suspension to shift visibly from the outside. “I’m just bored back here. We already know the schedule, why aren’t we busting in and getting things done?”

“Because it’s not Friday, when we’ll have all the gear we need,” Passenger informed him. “So our time is best spent acquiring as much information as we can. The better we know the people who’ll be in the building, the easier it will be to handle them. Besides, if any of them happen to be metas, there’s always the off-chance that they’ll slip up and show us their powers.”

“Though I think Abner is being pretty hopeful with that one,” Driver added. “Then again, we did have that freak storm a few weeks back. Never know who might be still figuring their shit out.”

Dirk chuckled and tried to pop his knuckles, though he only succeeded in producing weak sounds from the middle and index finger of his right hand. “Don’t you worry about that, Nelson. I’ve had years to learn how to handle myself. No newly-turned meta is going to be a challenge for me.”

Abner sighed from his spot in the passenger seat and made a few clicks on the keyboard. “A new meta would be fine. We have to worry about someone with actual practice hiding among them. Though, given that we’re expecting a staff of maybe fifteen during our operational window, the odds of that are staggeringly low. The chances of anyone in that building having meta powers are practically zero, especially ones strong enough to interfere with our plans. No one with any real juice would spend their time working in a dreary office.”

Abner didn’t know it, but in a way, he was dead right. On the day of their heist, there would not be *one* meta in the offices of Vendallia Technologies with them.

There would be four.

\* \* \*

When Beverly had gotten the offer to stay on guild premises during her apprenticeship, she'd immediately steeled herself for a worst case scenario. Her parents, both Marines, had told Beverly enough stories about their time in boot camp to give their daughter a healthy fear and respect of the lifestyle. Since that was the military and these were freaking villains, Beverly had gone in expecting to get a cot, a toothbrush, and a communal shower if she was lucky. What Beverly had failed to take into account was that criminals often turn to such activities to feed their hunger for a life of luxury, and in a guild full of them, that nature tended to impact how rooms were designed.

Her shower complete, Beverly changed into a t-shirt and yoga pants and tossed the damp towel into the laundry hamper, where it would vanish in the morning only to be replaced with a fluffy new one by lunch. The steam from her bathroom, small but private, was still wafting into her room as she slipped into the hallway. Shutting the door on her bed, computer, television, and moderately-sized bookshelf, Beverly charted a course for the nearest communal area. When she first arrived, they were places she had avoided, but once she realized no one was going to jump out and attack her, Beverly had grown bolder. Besides, after the weekend she'd had, it was becoming clear just how important making friends could be.

The break room on their floor was ostensibly only for rookies who hadn't yet made the cut. As such, it was more sparsely furnished than the ones she'd seen on other floors: just a pool table, foosball table, game rack, big flat screen, Indigo Gamesystem 4, couch, recliners, stove, oven, fridge, and pair of vending machines with sodas and snacks. Because this room was often without occupants, many of the other villains still ducked in out of habit. Plus, the sodas in the machine were only a quarter, which Beverly was pretty certain made it the last of its kind in the known world.

This evening, she could hear the sounds of explosions echoing down the hall long before she set foot inside. Sure enough, perched on the couch with a controller in one hand and a bag of chips in the other was Lance, whose on-screen avatar was shot in the head just as Beverly got a good look at the screen. A respawn counter popped up and Lance set down the controller, turning toward the soda machine and finally noticing Beverly.

“Hey! What’s up?” He hopped off the couch and practically threw a quarter into the soda machine. He grabbed the resulting root beer and raced back before the counter ran down.

“Not much. You playing with Arachno Bro again?” Unlike rookies, Arachno Bro had an IG4 in his room and played via online hook-up. At first, Beverly had taken it as an antisocial way to game until Lance explained that Arachno Bro had to use a specially-designed controller due to his arachnoid hands and was a bit self-conscious about it.

“We’ve got Xelas on too, though to be honest, I’m not sure if she even uses a controller. I swear I saw her walk by when her character was taking out an enemy sniper.” Lance popped the top on his drink, grabbed his controller, and waded back into the action as his muscular, gun-toting avatar reappeared on screen. “But man, this is a tough match. Most of the others are good, but they’ve got one guy who—motherfucker!”

On-screen, a creature that looked like a teddy bear mixed with a lizard darted by, not even pausing as it shot Lance’s tough guy straight through the skull. A new respawn counter appeared, and Beverly fought to resist the urge to chuckle as Lance seethed at the screen.

“I don’t know who Don Doomald is, but I wish I could send a swarm of bees to that dude’s house. He is freaking tough. They just opened up the shooter arenas in *Legacy World*, and the damn guy plays like he’s been doing it for years.”

“Maybe he does a lot of shooter games,” Beverly pointed out. She pulled a half-eaten sandwich out of the fridge and plopped down next to Lance. Oddly, no one had ever touched her food, even when she left it in the communal area. She wasn’t sure if it was courtesy or just pragmatism (not everyone ate things that were technically “food”), but she appreciated it all the same.

“Please. I’ve played my way through every game in the *Blaster Brah* series twice; that wouldn’t account for this kind of skill. Besides, judging by his level and gear, this guy is dedicated to the MMO. The expansion only came out a couple weeks ago, and he’s already at max level and wielding a top-tier staff of explosions. This is someone who has logged more hours on this game than Thuggernaut has at the gym.”

“That’s not a hard bar to hit; Thuggernaut doesn’t go to the gym much. His muscles are just a power side effect,” Beverly informed him.

“Well, just pretend I said something more fitting then, because I’m going back in.” Lance held his controller at the ready as the timer ticked away once more. He licked his lips and narrowed his eyes, ready for the instant his character reappeared. The time came at last. His avatar lifted what looked like a steampunk rocket launcher high on his shoulder and raced across the forest map they were playing on, big legs pumping and camera spinning as he searched for a target. It was thanks to the spinning camera that Lance caught sight of the teddy bear/lizard just before his character’s head was separated from his shoulders.

“Dude, are you fucking trying to sink us?” Xelas appeared outside the break room, glaring at Lance while her bird-like character swept down from the trees and rained fire on the screen.

“No! That little shit keeps getting the drop on me.”

“Then start looking around a little instead of running blindly through the jungle. Whoever wins this match has a chance to get the Vorpall Wings, and I will be downright *incensed* if you keep me from flying around and cutting people’s heads off. Pull it together. We like you, but it’s not too late to dump you in a river.” Xelas pointed at her glowing eyes, then at Lance, then back at her eyes. Beverly was reasonably sure that this was the metallic woman’s way of saying she was watching him.

Lance, for his part, took a deep breath, along with a drink from his root beer, as he tried to calm down and focus. Beverly found it strangely amusing that in this hive of scum and villainy, the biggest issue of the night was getting beaten in a video game. The longer she hung around this lot, the more she was starting to see the people underneath the reputation. Slowly she was coming to realize that the guild might be more than just a way to get her powers under control.

That was a thought for the future, however. For now, Beverly focused on eating her sandwich and watched Lance desperately try to stay alive.

## Chapter 31

Chloe moved quickly but carefully as she set up the cups, real sugars, fake sugars (pink, blue, *and* yellow), straws, creamer, and, of course, cardboard sleeves to keep people from burning themselves. Her large cart, formerly burdened with all of those necessities, still held the equipment for making the actual coffee, but that would come in a moment. People liked their java hot, and Ridge City Grinders made a point of delivering that.

Mr. Gerhardt, Tori's oddly serious boss, had explained that people tended to filter in depending on their personal responsibilities in the morning, so the bulk of the office would arrive a bit later than he and Tori. In Mr. Gerhardt's estimation, she'd only need one carafe of coffee to start, but once the others started rolling in she'd need to get brewing as fast as she could. Chloe had, of course, happily agreed. Rebuilding the coffee shop hadn't been cheap, and her boss had made it clear that scoring more catering gigs like this one would help bring in a lot more cash. He'd probably have done the job himself just to make sure it went well if not for the fact that Chloe had struck up something of a friendship with Tori, who'd brought them the work in the first place.

"Yo, how's it coming?" Tori poked her head around the edge of the break room, a wide grin on her face. As they'd let Chloe into the building and helped her up the elevator, Tori had explained that this was the final day of a very shitty week, so the overall mood in the office was likely to be ridiculously cheery. It seemed that even extended to her, as her often-somber veneer had been replaced by one verging on bubbly.

"Should have the first batch up and ready to go in five minutes," Chloe explained. "Is anyone going to mind if I move your usual equipment?" Chloe nodded to the drip-coffee maker on the counter where a half-full pot of unpalatable room temperature liquid sat undrunk from the previous day.

“I personally wouldn’t care if you threw the fuuuuu—er, *freaking* thing out the window. But better go check with the big man first, just to make sure. This place has some ridiculous rules about safety, I don’t want to get you in trouble.” Tori checked over her shoulder to make sure no one had caught her nearly cursing and then headed down the hallway toward Ivan’s office.

She passed by Donald as he unpacked his laptop when three people in motorcycle helmets burst out of the elevator, quickly targeting the employees with the weapons in their hands.

“Everyone stay calm and put your hands on your heads! If no one does anything stupid, you’re all going to get out of here just fine. If you get any ideas about being heroic...” The speaker, his sex betrayed by his voice, lifted his gun overhead and fired a single shot into the ceiling. While he spoke, his shorter companion ran through the cubes, forcing those few people at their desks to stand. The biggest of the lot lumbered his way down to the offices.

Tori forced herself to stay calm. She was so close to Donald that there was no way he wouldn’t notice a spike in heat. Instead of being angry, she focused on thinking the situation through. The group was wearing masks and thus hiding their identities, so there was at least a chance they meant what they said about letting everyone go. The rest of their bodies were covered in leather with oddly-shaped bumps inside: most likely some kind of body armor. At the moment, they were herding everyone together, and the main guy’s warning shot had been into the ceiling, not a human being. While she could probably tear all three of them apart without so much as a scratch, the same couldn’t be said for her coworkers. Everything pointed toward playing along, at least until she had a better understanding of the situation or found an opportunity to strike.

Moments later, she got confirmation that her thoughts were at least somewhat on point. Ivan calmly walked down the hall in front of the big one, hands on his head, his expression so calm that it was like this was just another day of performance reviews.

“This is the only one in the offices,” said the big one in a clearly-male voice. Tori would lay odds that the third was male as well, but it was

impossible to tell under all the padding.

“Guess that makes you the man in charge,” said the middle-sized one, who Tori suspected to be the leader.

“Normally, no; I’m merely middle management.” If Ivan was at all nervous, he hid it well. She noticed his eyes quickly scan the room, making sure everyone was unharmed—at least so far. “However, given that you are the one with the gun, I would say that for today, you’re the man in charge.”

“That is exactly right. You seem like a pretty smart guy. Just keep acting smart and we can all get out of here safe and sound. Do what we say, keep it simple, and don’t try to be a hero.”

Tori felt fairly certain she was the only one in the room who noticed the slight tug at the corner of Ivan’s mouth before he responded. “I can assure you that is the last thing I ever intend to be.”

“See, what’d I say? Smart guy. Now, tell all your people to gather up in the break room. They’ll be watched over by one of my guys while you come along and give us a hand. Your cell phones are jammed, landline is cut, and the exits are sealed, so it’s just us here today.” The man motioned to his smaller accomplice, who slowly and firmly herded people back toward the break room.

“May I ask what it is you’re after?” Ivan was still calm, but his attention was split as he watched his employees being corralled. Barb, the pleasant woman from HR whom Tori had learned was obsessed with her pugs, was taking a little long, resulting in the small criminal jabbing her in the ribs with their gun. Barb let out a small yelp of pain and hurried along.

The blow was largely for show, even if Barb would no doubt have a bruise later on, but Tori felt her inner fire try to rise up all the same. That was expected, though; that was who she was. What took her by surprise was, for a fleeting moment, the twitch of an expression on Ivan’s face that she’d almost never seen before. As Barb yelped and everyone half-glanced at her, Ivan’s mask slipped ever so slightly. What lay beneath it was nothing but naked fury. He was beyond livid at what these people were doing.



In that moment, Tori knew with unequivocal certainty that no matter what these three thought, this day would end in blood. And some of it, if not all, would be theirs.

“Now why would I go and bother telling you a thing like that?” The group’s leader had obviously missed what Tori had caught, otherwise he’d have either emptied his clip in Ivan’s skull or started running as fast as he could. Neither would have saved him.

“This floor of our company deals in software, so if you’re here to steal something related to that, I’d need to talk to one of our programmers,” Ivan explained, his veneer of calm fixed firmly in place once more. “Depending on the extent of what you’re trying to take, I might need to bring one along. As I said, I am only middle management, so I have my technical limits. I’d hate for this to come up later on and you take me as being uncooperative.”

“Don’t you worry about that. We know exactly what we’re here for. You just do as you’re told and everything will be fine.” The leader swung his head around slightly and nodded at the big thug behind Ivan. “Go help round everyone up, then keep an eye on the lot while we handle everything else. If they’re good, then be nice. If not... well, we warned them.”

A light tug on Tori’s wrist pulled her attention from the conversation. Donald, laptop bag still slung over his shoulder, was trying to head toward the break room and he’d grabbed the cuff of her jacket to pull her along. Much as she loathed to leave the scene before her, Tori let herself be led away. Ivan would be fine with two wannabe criminal masterminds. Hell, Ivan could probably take on half the AHC and be okay. The others, however, weren’t legendary villains hiding in plain sight. They might need looking after. And with the man formerly known as Fornax otherwise occupied, it fell to his apprentice to handle that job.

The big guy followed them into the break room and positioned himself in front of the entrance. There was no door to lock—something to do with fire safety—but with his wide shoulders, he easily filled the role. If not for Thuggernaut and some of the others in the guild, Tori would have thought him huge. As it was, she still wondered if he was a meta. It might change how she acted when things went bad, but at the moment, it had no

impact. She was just going to be good and sit between a pale Donald and a clearly nervous Chloe.

Tori would wait. Like a jungle cat crouched in the grass, she would wait.

\* \* \*

Ivan was sorely tempted to kill both his captors the minute his colleagues were out of sight. None of these idiots were with the guild; Vendallia was a well-hidden subsidy of Indigo Technologies, and as such would never be approved for a job. It would be akin to robbing one's own piggy bank. The only thing that stopped him from tearing the taller one's arm out of its socket and beating the other to death with it was the simple fact that he was here as Ivan Gerhardt. Not Pseudonym, and certainly not Fornax. If he ripped these two into shreds there would be a lot of questions and attention on him. His best bet was to wait it out and see if he could find a way to handle them in a way an office drone in his forties could easily do. Ideally, he'd be able to pin the glory on someone else, but the odds for that were shrinking by the moment.

"Everyone else is in the break room," said the smaller one, a high, somewhat nasal voice emanating from under the helmet. Ivan imagined it was a struggle for him to move under all that padding and leather. Slow reaction times, then... something to keep in mind.

"And now we get to see just how smart you really are. You're going to take us to your office and log on to the protected system, the one where Vendallia can access every fancy design or piece of code that's ever been put together." The leader motioned with his gun back down the office hallway and Ivan complied, even as everything fell into place.

Vendallia did work across a dozen industries, but with the effort these three were going through, they either had to be after data for banks or national security. A bank was far more likely, as they seemed at least smart enough to avoid pissing off the entire government. So they were likely bank robbers after the security protocols to bypass a bank's electronic deterrents. If Ivan were a betting man, he'd have guessed that they were killing two birds with one stone and using this as a trial run of their robbery.

The walk to his office was a short one. Without prompting, Ivan sat at his desk and reached for the computer. A *click* hit the air just before his fingers made contact. Ivan glanced up to see the taller one had pulled the hammer back on his gun. Given that he was holding an automatic, it was a pointless gesture done purely for the drama, but Ivan lifted his hands skyward all the same.

“I’m sorry, I thought you wanted me to log in?”

“We do, but that’s all we want you to do. No trying to send out a call for help.”

The smaller man reached over and quickly typed on Ivan’s computer. He had to give them credit; they’d certainly done their homework. It took no time until the secure server’s log-in screen flickered up, at which point the short criminal pulled back and offered Ivan the keyboard.

“Now it’s your turn,” said the leader, waving his gun at the keyboard.

Ivan tried to pretend he wasn’t insulted by the implied need for direction; instead, he simply went to work. The server they were after was tied to one of Indigo’s, which meant it had been built by Wade. As a criminal himself, no one was more safety-conscious than Wade Wyatt. As such, every member of the guild who worked a mundane job was given two access codes for secure systems: one to actually access them and one to log in to a dummy screen designed to stall anyone who went hunting for data while simultaneously alerting the guild.

If he really wanted to get out of this unscathed, accessing the true system was the right call. These men clearly hadn’t come with the intent of killing, and whatever they took could be documented and dealt with. It was the safer choice.

Without hesitation, Ivan entered the second password. These three idiots had stepped into his office and pointed guns at his employees. They’d unknowingly walked into the territory of monsters far beyond their comprehension. A debt had been incurred, and Ivan would see it paid in

blood before the day was done. He might be nothing more than a lowly dog of the guild, but he was at least a guard dog.

“You’re in,” Ivan lied, pulling his hands away from the keyboard.

“Nicely done,” the leader told him. “We’ll leave my friend here to work while you go join your colleagues. Just a little while until we get what we want, then you’re all free to start an early weekend.”

Moving slowly, hands still visible, Ivan stepped out of his chair and yielded it to the smaller robber, who hopped in and began typing without so much as a pause. The guy was obviously good. In other circumstances, Ivan might have offered him a job. Sadly, with a few notable meta exceptions, dead men didn’t code very well.

The leader walked Ivan into the hallway, away from the offices and toward the cube farms. His gun was still there, always close enough to Ivan not to miss but far enough away that it couldn’t be taken. Certainly not an amateur, Ivan had to give him that. Yet to make such a stupid mistake as to come in here... it seemed fate had decided this man’s time was up. And really, no time like the present. They were apart from his friends and Ivan’s colleagues with no witnesses to what would occur. Taking down two armed men? Impossible. Getting a lucky shot off? Unlikely, but a lot more believable, especially now that Wade was aware of the situation and would doctor all records as needed.

“May I ask you a question?” Ivan’s tone was as peaceful as ever, and he kept moving with the same slow, plodding pace.

“You just did,” replied the hostage-taker.

“Then another one. Did you know, when you came in here? I’m honestly curious. Did you have any idea just whose property you were stepping onto? I dearly want to believe you’re just unlucky, but part of me wonders if you really are just that stupid.”

“You think I’m scared of some big corporation? Money won’t stop bullets.”

“There are worse things than bullets.” Ivan stopped walking and turned slowly around. He couldn’t see the man’s face through the helmet

but he could hear his heartbeat quicken. Fear was spilling off him as he came to realize the situation was not as in control as he'd thought. Deep within Ivan, in a part he'd worked so very hard to seal away, something rattled against its cage, and the echoes resounded all the way to Ivan's brain.

"What do—" Those were the only words the robber got out before Ivan's hand wrapped itself around his neck like a vice. The power was bubbling up, and he knew that the last thing this man would see were his eyes, pitch black save for the glowing red runes.

"Sshhh." His voice was like a whisper from the shadows of an abandoned cemetery. "Time to suff—"

The *crack* of the gunshot cut him off. Ivan turned his altered eyes downward in disbelief. Somehow, through all the terror and asphyxiation, the son of a bitch had kept his head and squeezed off a shot. Of course, the bullet had bounced harmlessly off Ivan's skin, but he could already hear the people in the break room stirring. There were only seconds to work with... otherwise his entire life outside the guild would be nothing more than ash.

"Fucking hell." In one motion, Ivan snapped the man's neck and dropped him to the floor. An instant later, he fell down as well, casting a minor illusion as he went. By the time he landed, it appeared to anyone looking that he'd been shot through the side of his stomach and was slowly bleeding onto the carpet. His hand snagged the dented bullet; in seconds it was burned away to vapor.

Thinking quickly, he also scorched a few words into the carpet. If luck was on his side, it would fluster the robbers enough that they wouldn't see the real threat. Plus, it would be interesting to see how his apprentice handled herself. Training opportunities like this were few and far between.

## Chapter 32

Everyone in the room started at the sound of the gunshot, even the large man blocking their way. He started to lunge from the doorway, clearly intent on racing out, but stopped long enough to turn back in their direction.

“Nobody move, nobody try anything.” He punctuated this point by slapping his palm on one of the break room tables, shattering it to splinters. Admittedly, they weren’t exactly made from the finest of materials or the highest construction standards; however, it still got the message across. He was strong, and he could do the same to their bodies just as easily.

For Tori, she actually found some comfort in seeing him use his power. Like any good scientist, the more information she had, the more she could do with it. Knowing the big guy was a brute meant he’d be tough to bring down through physical means, but what he could manage was limited. She’d already hit on an idea to incapacitate him, assuming she could get the opportunity. By her estimations, Ivan had gotten a similar chance and taken it.

“What are you doing?” Chloe’s voice drew everyone’s attention. The bodies in the room noticeably stiffened as they realized Donald had slipped his laptop out of its bag and was rapidly typing away on the keyboard. Barb whimpered under her breath, huddling closer to one of the Stans—the one with the bushy mustache.

“The wireless is down, but I saved a few local copies, just in case.” Donald glanced up from his screen and nodded at the door. “Can... can someone tell me when he’s coming back? I think I have enough time, but I need to be sure.”

“Enough time for what?” Tori’s question was barely out before Stan started coughing into his hand. Without pause, Donald slapped the laptop shut and slid it back into his case. By the time the hulking figure appeared in the door again, it was like the device had never been removed.

“All of you, come with me,” demanded their captor. His voice was different than before, more tense. Something had gone off-plan, and Tori needed exactly one guess to know what. Or rather, who.

Everyone in the room stood and filed out. The Stans went first, the clean-shaven one slightly ahead of his mustached counterpart who was trying to comfort Barb; then, of course, went Barb herself. Rene and Carol, two of the programmers in Ivan’s department, went next. Tori tried to angle herself so she could bring up the rear, making her the muscle-man’s first target if things went bad, but Donald slipped behind her as Chloe moved forward, leaving himself in last place. That idiot. What was he thinking? This was not the time to pretend to be a hero.

Thankfully, no one was assaulted as they were marched into the cubicle area. That was a lucky break, as they’d all have been caught off guard, so absorbed were they with the sight that met their eyes.

Ivan was lying on the ground, a small pool of blood leaking from a gunshot wound in his side. His chest was still moving, so they weren’t supposed to take him for dead, but he did look paler than Tori recalled. When this was over, she’d have to ask him how he faked an injury with so little time.

Next to Ivan, limbs splayed akimbo, was the very evident corpse of the man who’d been leading the criminals. His helmet had been removed by the shorter goon, and they could see his face. It wasn’t one that would stick in any of their heads, partially because it was nondescript, but mostly because the jagged angle of his neck made it hard to stare at.

Shocking as both bodies were, it was the scene next to them that really drew one’s attention. Burned into the cheap office carpet were three words, small tendrils of smoke still curling up from the edges:

*You Missed One*

“Do any of you know about this?” The big man was behind them, waiting for someone to show a single sign of recognition. He was angry, that was easy to tell, but he was also scared. This was a strange scene to walk in on, one that hinted strongly at exactly one possible solution: there was an uncaptured meta loose in the building.

“All I know is Mr. Gerhardt’s bleeding out pretty quickly. If we don’t stabilize the wound, he might die.” Tori slid her foot slightly forward without taking the actual step. Showing intention was probably acceptable, but they might try to shoot her if she acted without permission. In a crowd this tight, even if it went through her fire-form, it would still end up hitting someone.

“Why do I give a shit about that?” The rumble of his voice was directly behind her, and Tori had a feeling that if he didn’t like the answer, a gun wouldn’t come into the equation. She could take this chucklefuck, but not without giving away what she really was. And letting that secret slip might *actually* get her killed.

“Because whatever did this, Mr. Gerhardt might have seen it,” Tori shot back. “If we can get him stabilized and wake him up, then he can tell you what happened. Or do you prefer going up against something that can do... that—” Tori gestured to the corpse on the ground “—with no knowledge about it whatsoever?”

“Or maybe he’s the one who did it,” the smaller one piped up, turning its gun toward Ivan. “Maybe he’s a meta, and we should just gun him down right now.”

“Whoever heard of a meta that can snap bones but gets put down by a handgun?” Donald asked, piping up just when Tori didn’t want him to. “We’ve all worked with Mr. Gerhardt for years, he’s never done anything remotely unnatural. Plus he’s literally bleeding out on the ground! Do you think he managed to carve an ominous message in the carpet while he was shot?”

The crowd muttered in agreement, and Tori could feel both of their captors grow tense. Taking hostages was one thing, killing them was another. Once death was on the table, being good little boys and girls didn’t seem like quite as smart of a play. With the possibility of a pissed-off meta in the building, the last thing they needed was an unruly crowd to deal with. Killing them all was an option, but one that removed any leverage they might have if the threat did turn out to be real. The wheels in their heads were almost audible as they spun, until at last the small robber moved his gun away from Ivan.



“Where’s the first aid kit?”

“Break room,” Tori replied quickly.

“Take him back in there then, get him patched. I want to know the minute he’s conscious. Everyone else is going with my big friend there. He’s going to put you in an office so we can make sure all of us stay safe. While they’re in there, I want someone combing through the HR records of every person who works here; see if any of them are self-outed as meta.”

“But that’s confidential,” Barb protested, earning her a sight down the barrel of the small one’s gun. To his credit, Stan pulled her closer, doing as best he could to put himself between her and the bullet.

“Looks like we know who’ll do the searching. Take them to the office next to the one I’m using. I’ll make sure the girl and the boss man are properly restrained.” He waved at the hallway, and the large man started herding the group back toward the offices.

“I’m going to need some help,” Tori protested. “I can’t just drag him across the floor. He needs to be lifted and carried carefully if you want him to live long enough to talk. I can manage with two others, unless you feel like helping out.”

“Fine,” snapped the shorter one. “You, coffee girl, you come help. And ginger-boy, you too.”

Chloe and Donald broke off from the pack and went with Tori to stand over Ivan. He was still breathing, though the motions of his chest seemed to be getting more shallow. Somehow she doubted Ivan intended to fake his own death, so it probably wouldn’t get much bleaker looking than this. Not unless the situation demanded it.

“Donald, you’re on legs. Chloe, take his left arm; I’ll get the right,” Tori ordered. Together, they lifted Ivan off the ground and delicately hauled him to the break room under the watchful gun of the littlest hostage-taker.

As soon as they’d set him on the clean linoleum floor, the robber went to work. He pulled zip ties from his pockets, cuffing Donald’s hands to the fridge and Chloe’s to the front latch of the soda machine. Tori he left free as she went to the clearly marked area on the wall and pulled out the

first aid kit. Only after she'd set it down next to Ivan did he take one of her hands as well, tethering her to the nearby cabinets.

"You'll need one free to work with," he explained, rooting through her supplies to make sure there was nothing sharp. "But try anything stupid and a bullet is going in each of your heads. I don't know what's going on. I just know that if something wants me dead, then I'd rather take people out with me. Clear?"

"Completely," Tori said. Chloe and Donald both nodded from their spots in the corner.

With order firmly established, the small man left, presumably to check on his accomplice. This left Tori with the task of trying to figure out how to give first aid to a man who was faking injury.

The only silver lining she could see was that, even as badly as the day had gone so far, it was still marginally better than doing more quarterly reviews.

\* \* \*

"Doctor Mechaniacal, sir?" Isotrix stuck his head tentatively through the office door where Wade was working. One of the upsides to being an eccentric genius inventor and head of a company was that no one at Indigo Technologies ever questioned his need for a private, off-site work area. Granted, they didn't know its location was actually smack dab in the middle of a guild full of former or potential villains that he'd helped found, but the only person he technically had to divulge that to was the IRS, and even then only if he wanted to take a deduction.

"What can I do for you?" Wade didn't bother to look up from the device on his work table; there was nothing that could be said which would require enough attention to draw his focus. Besides, he wanted to get this doodad knocked out early. After it was done, he'd have to find enough ways to dumb it down so that Indigo could replicate and manufacture it, which took far longer than the actual inventing, and then have it properly tested and marketed by the time Christmas rolled around.

“We got a ping on the security network, one of the high priority ones. Assistance teams are already mobilized, but this was on the list of networks you wanted to be personally notified about.” Isotrix shuffled from foot to foot; even after spending four years as Wade’s assistant, he still felt awkward interrupting the man’s work.

“Wait, don’t tell me. It’s the one tied to Pseudonym.” Wade let out a sound that was a strange combination of chuckle and exasperated sigh as he shook his head.

“That’s correct, sir. Did someone already tell you?”

“No, just a hunch. When you’ve been at this for as long as I have, you learn to play the odds. And the odds always say that if there’s trouble, he’ll be a part of it.” Wade set down his tools and turned to Isotrix, an act that only made the younger man grow somehow more tense. “Tell the teams that he’s more likely to need cover-ups and explanations than extractions. First priority is containment of his and his apprentice’s identities. Have them tweak personnel as necessary to make that happen.”

“Right away, sir.” Isotrix nodded so quickly that he inadvertently gave himself a headache. “Should they begin breaching immediately?”

“Oh, I’d give it a few minutes. Something tells me that by the time they make it, there won’t be much of a threat left.” Wade picked his tools back up and returned to his invention, a sly smirk on his face.

“After all, you can’t take the Fornax out of the Ivan.”

\* \* \*

It was almost impossibly frustrating to work on Ivan, keep pressure on the wound, wrap it in gauze, and pretend to be concerned all while knowing he was perfectly fine. This was what it meant to protect one’s identity, though, and now that she’d managed to get a small slice of life for herself, she could see why Ivan didn’t want to give his up. Nonetheless, it was annoying, and when the other two were looking away, she made a point of being as ungentle as possible.

“Damn it.” Donald’s curse was whispered and fierce as he tried in vain to pull apart the zip tie that bound his hands to the fridge. “If I could

just get to my laptop—”

“Then what, you’d send out a call for help?” Tori snapped. “They barred the doors on a Friday morning and shot off a gun. People know shit is up, and by now, someone has already called the cops. My guess is that they already accounted for that.”

“No, I wasn’t trying to call anyone. I was... look, this is really easier if I just show you than tell you,” Donald replied.

“Yeah, well, unless you’re going to get a whole lot stronger in the next five minutes, good luck with that.” Tori could all but taste Donald’s frustration, but that was for the best. Whatever half-cooked idea he had was only going to get him and probably others hurt. She needed to think of a plan, and the first step was finding an explanation for why her zip tie had suddenly melted into plastic goo.

“Do you really have a way to help us?” Chloe’s voice sounded almost alien. She’d gone silent since the criminals had burst through the front door. Something in her had changed, evidently, because now she was staring at Donald with an intensity Tori had only ever seen the woman use when working an espresso machine.

“I do. At least, I think I do. I’ve never tried this in real life before. Just lots of training.”

“You *think* you do.” Chloe took a long breath then glanced at Tori and Ivan’s supposedly severely injured form. “I guess that’s better than nothing. I don’t want to die here. Not this young, not so randomly, and for damn sure not in my barista apron.” She turned to Donald, resolve set in her face. “What was your name?”

“Donald. Donald Moss.”

“Well, Donald, things are going to be really weird for the next minute or so. You just need to roll with it and not make any noise if at all possible.” Chloe didn’t bother waiting for a reply; she closed her eyes and took a long, deep breath. When she spoke again, her voice was the same, yet worlds different. There was a vibration to them, something that rippled

through the air. Later, when she had the chance to think about it, Tori would realize the feeling reminded her of when Beverly had used the scroll.

***“What doesn’t kill you makes you stronger.”*** Chloe’s eyes snapped open as she spoke, and for a moment, her strange words hung heavy in the air like they were taking up a space of their own. It was an oddly tense moment that seemed to stretch on endlessly.

Then Chloe reached her leg out and kicked Donald squarely in the ass, which sort of broke the spell. It was only thanks to her warning that Donald stifled a yelp, and Tori heard a nervous giggle that she realized had made it past her own lips.

“What the hell?” Donald hissed, staring at her from his confined spot at the fridge.

“Are you dead?” Chloe shot back.

“No!”

“Then suck it up.” She kicked him again, and again, smacking the rear of his khakis with the toe of her shoe over and over. Finally, after around ten kicks, she pulled her leg back and nodded. “Okay, try it now.”

“Try what now?”

“The zip tie, dipshit.” Chloe rolled her eyes, and Tori found herself wondering if they could hire the blonde barista on as permanent staff.

Donald, suspicion evident on his face, tried to pull apart his zip ties again. This time, they started to give as soon as he began. With one burst of effort, they tore off with a slight pop. He stared at the broken binding device on the floor, then looked at Chloe, then back to the zip tie.

“What the hell...” he muttered softly.

“I don’t totally understand it myself, but when I use really old, cliché advice or sayings, they sort of... come true. My kicking you in the ass didn’t kill you, so you got stronger. Speaking of, ***‘A penny saved is a penny earned.’*** There, now you should be normal again. Didn’t want you to break your laptop by accident.”

“So, you can only do one at a time?” Tori asked as Donald quickly and quietly dug into his laptop bag.

“Yup. Soon as I use a new one, the old one cancels out. Took me a while to figure that out, or that I had powers at all. That weird lightning storm a couple of weeks ago was the cause, I guess. Now you both know my dirtiest secret: I’m a meta.”

“There’s nothing wrong with that,” Donald said, his face half-lit by the glowing screen of his computer. “Though I do appreciate you revealing your secret just to help us out. Turning into a meta is a scary experience, but sooner or later, they all have to share the truth with someone.”

Donald pounded on the keys for a few seconds more, then turned to look at Chloe and Tori, his eyes half-watered up with excitement and fear.

“I guess it’s my turn.”

## Chapter 33

No one aside from Donald was quite sure what he was doing as he reached toward the computer screen, especially when sparks and flashes of light started to erupt near his hand. The confusion only got worse when the light show stopped, because that was when Donald lifted up something that definitely hadn't been there before. To Tori it looked like an idiot had tried to build a gun—the thing was large, clunky, and had various flashing lights that would do nothing but give away one's position.

Chloe, on the hand, had a different reaction.

"Is that... is that the gun from *King Commander Cold*?"

"Good eye, and yes, it is," Donald confirmed. "I was affected by the storm too, only I got the power to pull digital stuff into the real world."

"Holy fuck," Tori said, her eyes going involuntarily wide. "You can bring out dragons and monsters and shit?"

"Well, no. It's only items. I can't bring out anything with an AI," Donald admitted. "But the things I bring out function just like they do in the games, which means I now have a way to harmlessly freeze these guys in place."

"Unless they shoot you in the head," Chloe pointed out.

"I do have more than one game on here." Donald tapped a few more keys. This time, he pulled out a buckler made of metal and glowing green light. "The Endless Shield from *Knights of the Cyber Hell*. It can handle any projectile they send my way."

"Awesome. Got anything in there to get us free?" Tori asked. While she had to admit that Donald's power did seem pretty impressive, it didn't change the fact that at least one of their captors was smart, or that the other seemed to be a meta himself. If Donald went out there alone with a freeze ray and fancy shield, he was probably going to end up smeared against the wall.

“Ummmm, all the swords would be too big. Oh, I know.”

Donald calmly stood and walked over to Chloe, made a few adjustments on his weird gun, and fired at her hands. She let out a small squeak, but when the blue ray vanished, not one bit of her flesh had been frozen. The same could not be said for the zip tie or the hunk of soda machine it was tied to. With a single twist, Chloe snapped the frozen zip tie into pieces, angling her legs so they hit her pants rather than the floor.

“The ability to freeze only objects so you wouldn’t hurt allies was a groundbreaking design feature in *King Commander Cold*,” Donald explained. He walked over to Tori and took aim, sending a wave of panic through her. Sure, it might not have hurt Chloe, but Chloe wasn’t partially composed of fucking fire, now was she? Still, it was either let him shoot her hand or have them try to fix things on their own. Powers or not, neither of them had any experience in this or any sort of combat, probably. If worse came to worse, there had to be someone at the guild who could patch her up. Hopefully.

A small flash of light, a deep cold feeling, and it was done. She’d gotten lucky; Donald’s toy hadn’t accidentally iced her hand clean off. Snapping her zip tie easily, Tori rose from her half-crouched position over Ivan and popped her back.

“Okay, look,” she said, thinking fast. “We need a plan. Donald’s items are really cool, no pun intended, but they’ve still got a lot of our friends hostage. Stopping these guys isn’t worth it if it means innocent people get killed.”

Chloe and Donald nodded in agreement, because of course they *did* agree; they were actually good people, not apprentice villains trying to fake their way through this. But it struck Tori that her words weren’t entirely for show. She really didn’t want any of her coworkers dead—not even Rene from programming, annoying kissass that he was. Tori sort of liked these people, at least enough to not want them listed as casualties. And Ivan wasn’t the only one who had a problem with people stepping onto his territory.

“Sooner or later, one of the guys is going to come check on Mr. Gerhardt—probably the little one so that the big fellow can keep an eye on



people who aren't supposed to be bound to office furniture. If we can freeze him before he screams for help, then we might be able to get the drop on the other one. Donald, does that thing do more than just act like liquid nitrogen?"

"It was made for a kid's game, so it's supposed to freeze people solid, but they melt—unharmd—after an hour or so. I've tried it out on roaches and a mouse in the alley near my house, and all of them seemed to be fine when they unfroze," Donald explained.

"I was actually asking if it kept people from yelling, but total body freezing works pretty well too," Tori said. "So the key to this will be you getting off the shot before he realizes anything is up. Think you can handle that?"

"I've been practicing," Donald admitted. From the way his eyes dropped, though, Tori had a feeling he knew he wasn't the best shot in the west yet. That was okay. With a little planning, they could still find a way to get him the window of opportunity he needed.

Unfortunately, it was just then that Tori heard the sound of soft footsteps coming toward the break room. They were officially out of time to plan or scheme in any capacity. That left Tori with only one option left: winging it. She felt oddly comfortable with that realization—at least flying by the seat of her pants was something she'd had practice with.

"Everyone, get back in your spots and pretend to be held. Donald, I'll find a way to get him distracted. Whatever you do, don't miss the damn shot."

\* \* \*

Unnoticed by anyone in the office, a ragged man with kaleidoscope eyes wearing a beaten coat appeared near the edge of the cube farm, tucked away in the office's entrance alcove. Nexus had no intention of interfering, of course; only on the rarest of occasions did he see a need to influence things directly, at least in this world. In certain others, he tended to be a bit more... hands on. But today, he had merely come to watch the show. It would be interesting to see how things played out here in one of the most unique universes he'd ever discovered.

Gathered in the break room were four people with the potential to change the world before them astronomically. Here, in this encounter, many possibilities would be destroyed while a myriad of others would be created. How this fight went often determined the paths of all four of them, though one's path would be far shorter than the others.

This universe was certainly unique, so it might surprise him, but in the overwhelming number of times Nexus had watched the next five minutes, one of the four almost always died. The only question today was who.

Leaning back so as not to be seen, Nexus carefully watched as the short man in the body armor made his way to the break room, unknowingly setting the wheels of fate in motion.

\* \* \*

Despite her bold promise, Tori actually had no idea what she was going to do to distract their captor. Her brain whirled with activity as the steps grew closer by the second, her eyes darting about the room as she worked to think her way through the situation.

The zip tie was in chunks, and while their captor might not notice Chloe and Donald's farce at first, she'd be busted the minute he stepped through the door. Subterfuge was out, which meant her best bet was to catch him off guard with an attack the minute he walked in. Of course, since he was pretty much protected from head to toe, the only strike that might work would require showing her powers to everyone in the room. Even that might not be effective enough, as the leather would protect him from the heat for at least the first few seconds—long enough for him to shoot at the others. She needed a way to hurt him so badly that he couldn't think straight, let alone take aim. It was the only way Donald would get a safe, clean shot.

Tori's wandering eyes stopped on the drip-pot with the plastic orange handle, full of cold coffee still sitting from the night before. An idea, seemingly from nowhere, popped into her head. Granted, it would still require using her powers, but in the ensuing chaos, she doubted anyone would notice. It wouldn't be quiet either, which was a big strike against it. Unfortunately, she couldn't come up with anything that would deliver on

that element, so it was better to pick the alternative that at least kept them all alive. Besides, the footsteps were almost at the door. She didn't have the luxury of thinking up something smarter.

In one motion, Tori snatched the coffee pot off the cold warming plate, doing her best to shield it from Donald and Chloe. One of the side effects from Ivan making her learn not to emit heat waves was that Tori had grown intimately aware of just how that aspect of her power functioned. For a change, she focused not on stopping her heat output but on directing it. She poured all of her anger, frustration, and general annoyance into that half-congealed coffee sludge. In mere seconds, it had reached a rolling boil. Tori kept at it. She turned up the heat as high as she could for as long as she could, using every last instant before the short man in leather walked through the break room door.

The moment he entered, Tori threw the coffee at him. She didn't aim for his head, where it would have bounced uselessly off the helmet, or his chest, where the leather would have taken the worst of it. No, Tori aimed right for his neck, spraying the super-heated liquid in the length between his collarbones. True, this part too was protected by leather, but the helmet was far from airtight. Burning steam poured upward into the helmet and their attacker's face.

Tori barely had time to shout "Now!" before the criminal's own yell drowned her out, unexpected and horrible screams tearing from his throat. They were mercifully cut short as Donald fired. Their would-be captor suddenly froze in mid-panicked flail, his torso stretched backward and his hands clutched futilely at the helmet that had sealed in the painful steam. Even without being able to see his face, they could practically feel the pain just from his stance. Everyone made a concentrated effort not to look at him as they gathered together in the middle of the room.

"We got him," Donald said, holding his freeze-gun at the ready. "But it wasn't exactly the silent take-down we were hoping for."

"Sorry about that, I sort of panicked and went with the first thing I could think of. I've gotten blasted by the steam from enough cups of coffee to know it would at least hurt. Guess it was hotter than I expected." Tori tilted her head to the drip-pot maker, still sitting useless on the counter. As

far as covers went, it wasn't a great one, but she highly doubted anyone would fact-check it.

"Maybe we got lucky and the big guy didn't hear it," Chloe said.

"Abner?" The voice called out through the office, nearly rumbling the tiles as it did. No such luck: the big guy had heard the screams. Their best case scenario was that he'd try to come kill them. Worst case would be if he was smart enough to use the hostages; though, given that he seemed to be using the frozen crook's real name, that seemed somewhat unlikely.

"What do we do?" Donald looked at both of them, gun shaking slightly as his eyes went wide.

"You're asking *us*? I'm an administrative assistant and she makes old sayings come true. You're the one with the ability to turn video game shit real," Tori pointed out.

"Right," Donald said. His shaking gun slowly steadied, and a determined gleam seemed to twinkle in his eye. "You're right. This is mine. I can handle it. He might be strong, but he probably still freezes just like anyone else."

Tori chanced a look at Ivan, who was still doing an excellent impression of someone who'd been shot and poorly bandaged. She dearly wished he would stop the act and talk to her, if only for a few moments. The truth of the matter was that without knowing what sort of meta the big guy was or where his powers came from, there was no way of telling how Donald's beam would work on him. Even Tori's flames might be useless, depending on exactly what abilities and immunities he had. Her time in the guild had shown her just how broad the meta spectrum really was, and she knew well enough to take nothing for granted. But... it wasn't like they had any better options, was it?

"You shoot him; Chloe and I will try and distract him," Tori said.

"How do you plan on us doing that?" Chloe didn't look scared, not exactly, but she was eyeing Tori in a new way. It looked more suspicious than anything else, which caused Tori a twinge of worry, but she'd just have to deal with that later.

“Easy. We shoot him too.” Reaching over to the frozen man wracked in pain, Tori pulled a pair of handguns from the myriad of weapons strapped across his body. They were mildly cold, more like they’d been left outside in autumn than stuck in a freezer, so she hoped they would still fire. Tori checked the clip on one then handed it over to Chloe.

“Only shoot at the big guy, and don’t even try that if he has a hostage.” As Tori spoke, the rumblings of heavy footsteps slammed through the office. “He’s strong, so he’s probably tough on top of having body armor, which means the most we’ll do with these is annoy him. Donald, we’re counting on you.”

“Don’t worry. I can handle this.” No one was sure if Donald was trying to convince them or himself, but there wasn’t time to argue. Those heavy thuds were growing louder, and no one wanted to try and deal with the big man in an enclosed space.

“As soon as we’re out the door, spread out,” Tori ordered. “He’s big, so although we might be faster, there’s a good chance he’ll barrel right through the furniture and cubicles. Don’t count on them for cover. Stay spry, keep moving, never let him pin you in a corner. And for heaven’s sake, let’s all try not to get anyone killed out there, especially ourselves.”

## Chapter 34

The bulky kidnapper was thudding through the cubicle area when all three of the former hostages burst out of the break room. Despite having been brought on for muscle more than brains, he could still tell when a situation had gone sideways. Three office workers storming into view with guns in hand tripped his awareness pretty handily. And so it was that the man threw himself down and rolled to the side, easily avoiding the freezing beam of Donald's first shot.

"That's a weird-looking gun you got there." He stayed low, peeking up as little as possible to see where the three had fanned out. "Is that the gun that made Abner scream so loud?"

"Nah, your little buddy just can't handle his caffeine." Tori fired a bullet near the hulking man's position, clipping the top of a felt-covered cube wall. It was nowhere close to a clean shot, but she hadn't really expected to hit him. All she'd wanted to do with the first shot was make sure the gun worked and draw his attention. On the first goal, at least, she succeeded; however, his helmet-shielded gaze stayed aimed right at Donald. Damn. He was smart enough to keep his eyes on the prize—in this case, the prize being the one of them holding unnatural equipment. Tori read him loud and clear: handguns were useless on him, but the mystery gun might not be, and thus needed to be carefully observed.

She really hated when her opponents weren't idiots.

"You can still walk away from this, you know," Tori called out. "Both of your cohorts might be down for the count, but you can probably smash right through this wall and make your escape. The job is a bust. You must see that. Your best bet is to get clear and live to rob another day."

Of course, that day would never come; she'd seen the look in Ivan's eyes. One way or another, this was the date that would be on the big man's headstone.

“Yeah, that’s probably the smart call.” His hands moved somewhere out of sight, and Tori had just enough time to register a slight crunching sound before a dark object whipped through the air. “‘Course, I’m not all that famous for my smarts.”

The object, a tower wrested from one of the many desktops scattered about the cubes, rushed forward on a beeline with Donald’s skull. It was too fast for him to dodge; she doubted he even had the chance to register it. Luckily, Donald hadn’t walked into the fight without some protection of his own. The buckler on his arm flashed, and for a moment, Donald was surrounded by a perfect sphere of light. Loud smashing and clattering filled the room as the tower slammed against the light, turning to debris and tumbling harmlessly to the floor.

“I’ll be damned. You have some pretty neat toys. Surprised to find you working in a place like this.” Their opponent didn’t seem bothered by his failed attack. He stayed low and crept through the cube farm. More muffled crunching sounds were the only warning Tori had that he’d restocked his supply, not that it would do any good. Donald’s defenses were top notch.

It hit her just before she saw the desktop tower screaming toward her chest: Donald wasn’t the only viable target in the room. Years of petty crime, fighting off muggers, and perhaps a little of the guild’s training all kicked in at once. Without a thought, Tori leapt to the side, narrowly avoiding the hunk of electronics that shattered on the wall near her. Chloe, however, didn’t have all of her experience and training.

“Fuck!” On the upside, Chloe had managed to get partly out of the way, but her yelp coupled with the audible crunch as the tower struck her hips made it clear she’d taken an injury. Worse than that, even from across the room Tori could see it was an obvious effort for her to keep standing. She’d be unable to pull off even another half-dodge.

Tori watched the blonde barista mutter something under her breath. It was impossible to tell what the words were, but the most Tori could hope for was that there was an old saying that made people immune to flying computers.

“Looks like the girls don’t have fancy shields or guns.” He was moving through the cubes again, no doubt reloading. Periodically, Tori would get good shots at his limbs or shoulders—there was too much bulk to completely conceal—but she didn’t bother taking them. Wasting ammunition wouldn’t do them any good, at least not for the moment. She needed to think of a way to draw him into the open, to give Donald an actual shot. And she needed to do it soon.

“How about we make a deal? You throw down the gadgets, I promise not to hurt any more of these nice people. Maybe you’ve got connections or powers, but we both know you aren’t a cape. Keep pretending and you’re going to get someone hurt.”

Donald’s eyes swept the area, searching for his chance, but Tori could already see his determination wavering. The huge jerk wasn’t wrong, after all. Donald was as far from a cape as one could get and still be considered a meta. Shit, Tori was closer to a cape than he was—at least she’d had some training and combat experience. Cape or not, though, Donald was the closest thing to a champion they had, so he would have to do. By any means necessary.

“Hey, Donald, same deal as last time,” Tori called. She brought her gun to the ready and lowered her stance. All that talking and moving about had given her a clear idea of where the last hostage-taker was in the array of cubicles. He was too low to shoot at, true, but that didn’t mean she couldn’t find him. “Whatever you do, don’t miss. Even if you have to take two instead of one.”

Before Donald could manage more than a half-formed attempt at a question, Tori was off, racing through the cubicles. It took all of ten seconds and two quick turns to find the near-giant crouched down on the ground, a small pile of desktop towers at his feet. Though she couldn’t see his face through the helmet, she still noticed his visible shock as she came whipping around the bend in a head-on charge. Shock was the right emotion, too. After all, he was a powerful meta and she looked like nothing more than an average woman ready to face the final workday of the week—what could she hope to accomplish with such a pointless attack?



Without slowing down, Tori leapt on the large man's back, jammed the gun under his helmet as best she could, and pulled the trigger. Even those who could shrug off a lot of damage had some places on their body were tougher than others. If he was going to have a spot weak enough to let a bullet through, the top of his neck and area under his jaw were her best bets.

Tori squeezed the trigger three times before a large hand wrapped around her own. He easily yanked her off his back, squeezing her hand so tightly it was a miracle her fingers didn't completely shatter.

"This one has guts," he said, his body still hunched over even as he dangled Tori a foot off the ground. "I admire that, I really do. Tell you what, out of respect for her guts, I'm going to give you until the count of three to —"

His next demand or threat would forever remain a mystery. The entire room filled with a thunderous roaring that shook the very desks. It sounded like a wolf the size of a bus had broken in to demand a tribute of flesh. The criminal, Tori still clutched firmly in his hands, leapt up from his hiding spot on pure instinct. Meta or not, humans were hardwired to react in certain ways when a predator was nearby, and the first course of action was to locate the threat.

Unfortunately for the large man, Donald had somehow kept his cool in the face of the noise. No sooner had the crook crested the top of the cubicles than a bright blue beam struck him in the chest. His grip on Tori loosened and she wriggled free, dropping to the ground and rolling away from her opponent. Springing back to her feet, she quickly surveyed the room for the source of the noise, only to find Chloe opening and closing her mouth in sync with the terrible barks. Strangely, the blonde woman had bruises forming around her jaw and a trickle of blood seeping out of her mouth, but her eyes were full of fire.

When she finally halted the wall-shaking distraction, Tori asked the obvious question. "What in the nine hells was that?"

"My bark is worse than my bite." Chloe winced with every word she spoke, her eyes watering from what Tori assumed was pain. The halfhearted

explanation left Tori with many questions, but she wouldn't get to ask them quite yet.

"I haven't felt that kind of cold since I was kid and my dad locked me out of the house in January." Moving slowly, but still very much moving, the large man reached up and slapped his chest three times. He turned his helmet to face Donald. "Guess I've gotten tougher since then."

"Fuck us all, he's resilient," Tori whispered softly. It was just what she'd been afraid of: the bastard was a meta that could withstand the effects of certain attacks, freeze-guns evidently included. A strong enough strike could still overcome his defenses, but Donald had shown them the best his blaster could do and all Tori's tech was half-built and stashed under Ivan's house. Unless Chloe had a super powerful phrase up her sleeve, they were out of options for stopping this guy. Even if she blasted him with heat, he could probably endure it. The only one of them who could easily stop this son of a bitch was down in the break room, pretending to be shot.

Stealth, it seemed, was no longer deemed necessary by the wide-shouldered criminal. Without turning his head from Donald, he barreled forward, taking two more shots from the freeze-gun as he tore through the desks like they weren't even there. While each blast did seem to slow him, he kept right on coming, reaching back and throwing a punch that would easily tear Donald's head from his slender body.

Just before impact, the glowing sphere reappeared from Donald's buckler, valiantly putting itself between his too-frail skull and the meta's fist. This didn't deter Donald's attacker in the slightest; he kept right on slamming his fists down on the shield over and over. That alone would have been worrisome enough, but after the first few attacks, Tori noticed that the sphere seemed to be flickering on impact. Not even video game shields had infinite energy, after all.

Donald had a minute before he would be no more than powdered bone and organs, if that. Tori had to work fast. She could only think of one way that might stop this jerk, or at least draw his focus, and she'd need to work quickly to make it happen.

Rushing over to Chloe, Tori grabbed her fellow hostage by the shoulder and shook, pulling her attention away from Donald's predicament.

“Chloe! That thing you did with Donald, the ‘what doesn’t kill you’ thing: does that work the way it looks? The more you get hurt, the stronger you get?”

Chloe blinked a few times then slurred out a response. “It’s proportional, from what I’ve seen. I don’t think you could get hurt enough to stop him, though.” Her eyes flicked back to the man pummeling Donald’s shield, a shield that was beginning to flash violently on every punch.

“Do it to me. Now. Please.”

With a curious, sidelong glance, Chloe muttered, “***What doesn’t kill you makes you stronger.***”

“Thanks.” Tori lifted the gun in her right hand, pressed it to her own left arm, and fired. Those lessons from Ivan were paying big dividends: she forced her body to resist its instinct to turn to fire and accepted the wound as it tore apart her flesh.

Chloe yelled in shock, but neither Donald nor the man trying to kill him seemed to notice the gunshot. Nor did they notice the next one Tori used to shoot lower down her arm, nor the next, nor the next. After the pain from gunshot number four nearly caused her to pass out, it was time to roll the dice. She wouldn’t do much good if she gave in to shock, now would she?

Racing forward, trying dearly to ignore the throbbing pain in her ruined left arm, Tori ran up behind the man trying to murder her friend and punched the back of his motorcycle helmet with everything she had. The helmet exploded into fragments. He hurtled forward, tumbling through the air until he slammed violently into a wall. Face exposed for the first time since arriving, the man turned and stared at Tori with a combination of confusion and annoyance.

Donald, on the other hand, was panting on the ground, seconds away from a panic attack as far as she could tell. The buckler on his arm was flashing with a red light, which, by video game logic, probably meant it was about to run out of juice. She’d been just in time.

“How did you—”

“Same way you broke the zip ties, I just didn’t have time for Chloe to kick me in the ass,” Tori snapped. “Now, up and at it. Big Papa isn’t out of this fight yet.”

“No, he isn’t,” rumbled the large man as he hauled himself up. He carefully rubbed the back of his head, wincing visibly at the touch of his own fingertips. “But you three are turning out to be quite the annoyance. I don’t even give a shit about the job anymore; I just want to pay you back for causing this much of a headache.”

“Hey, Donald, this is just me talking here, but I’m betting that your gun is like every other gun out there: it works a lot better when you shoot people in the head. Especially now that it’s exposed.” Tori didn’t bother whispering; they were all too close together for the target not to hear. Besides, he wasn’t that stupid. With the helmet gone, he knew where the next shot would be aimed. He’d probably dodge it, too, which was why Tori didn’t plan on giving him the chance.

She barreled forward, charging the big man before he could do the same to them. With Tori starting from as far away as she had and telegraphing the move so clearly, he had ample time to dodge out of the way. Just as she’d hoped, he went for a counter instead, grabbing her around the chest and locking her in place. For a guy with his strength, it was probably pure reaction to render someone nearly helpless and then pound them into submission. What he hadn’t had time to adjust to yet, however, was the fact that Tori had some extra strength of her own. Rearing up her right hand, she punched him in the calf as hard as she could, savoring the slight popping sound she heard from the bone.

It was less satisfying a moment later when he buried his fist in her stomach. Despite the fact that she jumped with the punch to disperse the momentum, Tori nearly lost control right then and there. Her instincts screamed at her to go into fire-form. She’d probably need to spend the rest of the day in flames to regenerate—her ribs felt like shrapnel more than bones and her arm was gushing blood in a streaming torrent. But that would come later. For the moment, he’d done a great job of hurting her worse than a gunshot, and with the added benefit of not killing her.

Tori grabbed the arm holding her and squeezed, finding his flesh more pliable with the extra addition of strength. A slight yelp of pain and surprise escaped his lips and he released his hold; no doubt he was trying to regroup and understand what just happened. Tori was having none of that shit, though. She would end this, right here and now.

His arm firmly in her grasp, she yanked it around to his back, half-wrenching his giant shoulder out of its socket. This time she didn't need to give Donald his cue. Flashes of blue light lit up the large man's pain-stricken face one after the other until the arm clutched tightly in her hand went limp. She held on through a few more shots before releasing her iron grip and letting him slump to the floor.

"If one of you would be so kind as to dial emergency services, I think my assistant and I are in need of medical attention." Standing in the door-less doorway of the break room was Ivan, still pale and seemingly covered in blood, but smiling in a way Tori had only caught glimpses of. The old bastard was beaming with pride, and as her consciousness finally gave way to the pain and shock flooding her system, Tori realized that he wasn't the only one.

She was pretty damn proud of herself, too.

\* \* \*

Nexus vanished from his hiding spot and reappeared across the street, watching as guild members pretending to be police and EMTs rushed into the building. Normally they'd be bagging a body before anything else, but today it seemed that only some spot-healing and basic cover-up work would be needed.

In truth, he wasn't that surprised to see everyone make it through alive. This universe was always unpredictable; it had been from the moment it created Quorum instead of a hole in the ground like literally every other iteration had. It surprised him, intrigued him, always kept him guessing. In a way this was Nexus's favorite piece of the multiverse, though it was also the one he hated the most, for the same reasons.

At least things would remain entertaining now. A world where one dodged the computer, one's shield held out, and one jumped just enough to

not be killed by the punch to the stomach... that was a world where many fascinating things would certainly occur.

All for Nexus to watch, and—perhaps on occasion—influence. Interactive entertainment was his absolute favorite.

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## Chapter 35

Tori awoke to find herself in a room full of white light, the pain in her arm and stomach greatly reduced, but not entirely gone. She started to sit up only to feel the white room spin underneath her.

“Go slowly. You’re going to be dizzy for a while.” Ivan was seated on a small stool in the corner of the room, the tablet in his hand occupying most of his attention. “The genetic regeneration and reconstitution rooms are handy for getting people back on their feet, but all that healing in such a short time tends to leave people with a bad case of the spins.”

For once, Tori didn’t argue and eased herself slowly into a sitting position. Bit by bit, the room stabilized until she was able to admire the tech surrounding her. Fixed to the ceiling at various points were large, strangely-wired lamps that were dousing her in that curious white light. Obviously, it wasn’t just light; they must have been pumping out some sort of beams or radiation designed to promote inhumanly-accelerated healing.

“You know, if every hospital in the world had one of these rooms, a lot fewer people would die,” Tori pointed out.

“Unfortunately, the R&R rooms only work on meta-humans, and not even all of them, at that. If you think they should come standard in hospitals, talk to Professor Quantum; he’s the one who invented the technology.” Ivan rose from his seat and walked slowly over to Tori, tablet still firmly clutched in his hand.

“How nice of him to share his breakthroughs with a bunch of criminals,” Tori replied.

“Did you think you were the first scientist to realize that sometimes stealing tech is easier than recreating it? We *are* a guild of villains, after all.”

“Hopefully that means you didn’t kill off everyone in the office to cover our tracks.” Tori was mostly joking, but in her time with Ivan she’d learned not to underestimate the people she’d been thrown in with. Fun as

they might be, it was her folly if she forgot the lengths they would go to, should the need arise. It was just like Ivan said: they were a guild of villains, after all.

“Now, why would we need to go and do a thing like that?” Ivan held the tablet out in front of her and pressed the play button on an archived video feed from a press conference. Standing in front of the office building where they’d been taken prisoner, surrounded by a sea of reporters, was Donald, looking far more scared than he had while taking on the men with guns. Next to him was the familiar face of Apollo, arm wrapped around Donald and white smile catching the flashes of all the cameras.

“As the story is being reported, Donald Moss, a recently altered meta, used his powers to defeat a gang of thieves out to steal restricted data from a programming company. He did so without losing so much as a single life, though some members of the staff were injured in the chaos. Those sustaining injuries were rushed to a top-tier medical facility staffed with metas with healing abilities at the expense of their employer. Donald was the lone meta on the scene, though he made sure to mention that without the help of his coworkers, this victory would not have been possible. The Alliance of Heroic Champions has already offered him membership; they’re not the kind to let a golden PR opportunity like this slip away.”

“But Donald wasn’t the only one, not even just besides us,” Tori protested. “Chloe—”

“Chloe is a very brave young woman who doubtlessly helped save lives today, but she is also happier living outside the limelight, at least for now. It was at her request that Donald took all the credit. She convinced him that he would be protecting her secret. This life, his or ours, isn’t for everyone.”

“You’re not going to try and recruit her either?” Tori found herself skeptical, though she had to admit Ivan wasn’t one to make false claims. Usually he just told her how things would be, whether she liked it or not.

“We don’t ‘recruit’ like that. We take in those who are likely to run afoul of us by breaking the code, if we can get them early enough, or those whose powers are too dangerous to run rampant without training. As you



might recall, you were only dragged in here because you broke into a secure facility.”

“Does that mean the big dude we stopped is going to be joining the other rookies?”

Ivan’s face darkened, only for a moment, but Tori knew what she saw. “No. He doesn’t quite possess the self-control we look for in our recruits. Had he taken the chance to run when you offered it, perhaps an exception might have been made. But he chose violence over prudence, and that is not our way. Besides, your crime was managed and performed in private, while his was broadcasted across the news. We have to set a standard of expectations for what happens to those who try and break into our companies.”

“I get the feeling I don’t want to know any more about this, so I won’t ask,” Tori said.

“Smart call.”

“But that doesn’t mean I don’t have other questions. Like: how are you going to explain away your little message in the carpet? So far as everyone else in the office knows, there was another meta on the scene who killed the first guy.”

“Ah, you must mean when I struggled with the man who had a gun on me, knocking him against the edge of the desk and accidentally breaking his neck after he shot me. True, he did have some acid that spilled and corroded the carpet, but calling it a message is a bit of a stretch.” Ivan reached up and tapped one of the suspended lamps blaring light on Tori. “We’ve got more than just physical aftermath covered; several of our guild members have either the magic or the abilities to cloud the mind. Obscuring whole memories would be tricky and temporary; however, nudging the details a bit is so subtle only the most self-aware of people notice it.”

“Well, that’s peachy for you. If I’d known we had memory changers I might have come up with a solution besides shooting myself in the arm four times.” Tori tested her left arm, finding it stiff and painful but once again functional. Good as the lights no doubt were, she’d feel a lot better once she went into fire-form and fixed herself up.

“As I said, *small* changes are easy. There’s a reason I had to play dead, after all. But I think, even with the restrictions placed upon you, you did very well, my apprentice. You protected your friends, you took down the intruders, and you managed it all without using your powers in an overt manner. The caution and prudence you showed today will go a long way toward your membership in this guild.”

“Oh man, please tell me you didn’t set this whole thing up just as a way to test me,” Tori said.

Ivan laughed softly under his breath, yet somehow it still managed to fill the room. “Sadly, even my level of conniving has limits, and this is one of them. Fate is often a far better teacher than we could ever hope to be.”

“Thank goodness.” Tori leaned back in her bed, shutting her eyes to diminish the waves of dizziness that accompanied all movement. “When we get home, the first thing I’m going to do is start working on some portable tech to keep in the office. Next I’m putting a prototype of my suit together. If today has taught me anything, it’s that I do not like being caught unarmed.”

“With strong powers and a good mind, we are never truly unarmed,” Ivan replied. “But I’m afraid you won’t be going home tonight. Since there is apprentice training tomorrow, it was decided that you would stay the night here to fully recover. After all, we neither have the lights nor a fireproof room at the house.”

“Wait, is this bed fireproof?” Tori looked down at the sheets and firm mattress under her; so far as she could tell, they seemed completely normal.

“Fire-resistant is a better way to put it; nothing is really fire-proof. So long as you don’t actively try to burn it, you should be fine. A few sets of sheets were commissioned the first week you were recruited, well before you became my apprentice. The softest of these are in your room here, by the way.”

“Oh geez, that fucking cot back at the training facility? Thanks, but no thanks.” Tori had slept on worse during the darker times in her life, but

not by much.

“No, that was a cheap measure while the fireproof ones were being made. I’m talking about your room here, at the guild,” Ivan replied. “Every member has one, even apprentices, and you are no exception. They aren’t extravagant, but sometimes we just need a place to hole up; this allows us to do so. When your apprenticeship under me comes to an end, presuming it’s a good one, you’ll be allowed to move in here, if you so choose.”

“That’s awfully generous of the guild,” Tori said. She’d seen the way members were treated and it was always kind, but free rooms would take a lot of space and get highly expensive.

“We find that people make fewer stupid mistakes when they know they always have a place they can call home,” Ivan said. “Sometimes just having a place to go back to gives them the mental strength to keep on the code’s path.”

That actually rang true. The most desperate, harshest times Tori could remember were when she was scrounging for a home base, a place to be safe amid the chaos. Even in last week’s trials, the first thing she’d done was find a safe spot to hunker down. It was human nature. Providing such a luxury had probably saved the guild from having to deal with several of its members going off the rails throughout the years.

“I guess I’ll check it out once the dizziness fades, if that’s okay,” Tori said.

“It won’t fade while you’re under the lights, but I’ll get you a wheelchair and bring you over to it myself.” Ivan turned toward the door, but Tori’s hand grabbed his sleeve and held him in place.

“Be honest with me: how much more of this do I have to go through? I like learning from you, and I’m grateful for what you’ve done, but the longer this sword dangles over my head, the heavier its shadow gets. Give me a quarterly review so we can plan my next steps if you have to; just paint me a finish line.”

Ivan slowly turned back to her and gently rested his hand on top of hers. “This weekend, you’re going to learn how jobs with the guild work.

For the next two weeks after that, you'll be getting field training every night. At the end of that time, you will participate in a job, one you can orchestrate either by yourself or with others. How you do on that job, coupled with the judgment you've shown during your other trials, will determine if we believe you can adhere to the code. I can't tell you how that job will go, Apprentice, only that when it's done, you will either be a member of the guild or dealt with accordingly."

Tori tried to release her grip, but Ivan held firm for a few seconds longer. "I should also add that as your teacher, my opinion is considered the highest prized regarding whether you can join the guild or not. And as things stand now, you have impressed me at almost every turn. Keep going the way you have, and I will fight tooth and nail to win you the admission you'll have earned."

A slight smile appeared on Ivan's face as he released her hand and eased the heaviness of the discussion. "And you'll be glad to know that since we were both injured on company property, they're going to complete the rest of the quarterly evaluations without us."

"You know, I think that's actually worth the broken ribs and bullet wounds."

\* \* \*

Abner sat in the jail cell, no longer clad in leather or armor, listening to the small sound of leaking water as it dripped from somewhere in the building's concrete depths. Dirk was being held someplace where his strength couldn't be used to free him, and Nelson was dead. He'd been so careful in planning everything, in doing the research, in learning everything he could about the people who worked there. How could it all have gone so wrong? The entire plan shot to shit, his face still burned from that fucking steam, two of them in jail, and all because some lone meta had managed to get the drop on them. The buyer for the information was long in the wind by now; he'd kept himself far enough removed that Abner couldn't point a finger, even if he'd wanted to.

The sole bright spot Abner could see was that Dirk and Nelson had been the only ones to get their hands dirty. He'd never fired so much as a single shot at anyone, even after that bitch threw coffee on his face. The

mere thought of it caused the burns on his skin to flare up with pain, which Abner dutifully ignored. There was a chance he could skate by on this; after all, he'd let them tend to a wounded man. If he claimed that Nelson had spearheaded it and Dirk had forced him along, there was a chance he could beat the charges. Dirk was confirmed to be violent and Nelson was dead; there was no one left to give credible testimony against him. It was a rule he lived by: never leave unnecessary witnesses. It had cost him a few bullets and shallow graves, but this time, fate had been on his side. Without so much as a drop of blood on his hands, he could coast to freedom.

"Hello."

Abner jumped in shock at the voice then turned to stare at the man with long, dirty-blond hair who had appeared in his cell. He wore an almost serene expression as he moved toward Abner, kneeling down to look the seated man in the eyes.

"Who are you?" It wasn't the most apt question to ask at the moment, but Abner's brain was hardly firing on all cylinders.

"I'm Kristoph. They let me go in first to check people, just in case." That serene expression darkened. Abner felt his stomach churning in fear even before his brain could process why.

"You... are a bad man. You killed them in Guatemala, just because they saw you loading your bags. You killed them and threw their bodies into the river."

Abner's eyes went wide in shock. He'd never told anyone, not even Nelson, about the two children he'd murdered to keep his face unknown. Yet Kristoph knew. As he rose to his feet, a new energy swirled through the air. On the concrete walls of the prison cell, Abner noticed the moving shadows and saw what was sprouting from Kristoph's back.

"You are a bad man." All peace was gone from his voice; it was as though Abner was hearing the very judgment of a wrathful god. "And you will suffer for your sins."

By the time the guards made it to the cell, the screaming had finally stopped, though what remained there would haunt their nightmares for

years to come.

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## Chapter 36

“My oh my, the ability to turn digital items into real things. That is incredible.” Apollo was sitting across from Donald between two constantly-smiling people he’d introduced as Jessica and Barney. “And to have such a public debut, why, you’ve done the bulk of the work for us, which we always appreciate. Now, since you’ll be pulling out and using material that is trademarked or copyrighted by a slew of various companies, we’ll need to either get some waivers signed or have the lawyer get a defense ready to go when the lawsuits come rolling in.”

“Storybook already set the precedent with her literary minions,” Jessica replied, barely looking up from her laptop as she took down Apollo’s requests. “Courts ruled that a meta conjuring protected material doesn’t violate the copyright, so no damages can be sought.”

“Really? That’s a surprisingly favorable decision for the meta,” Apollo noted.

“It was right after Storybook helped save an entire city, and the company suing her was found to have some unethical dealings with child labor overseas. The PR was a tidal wave they couldn’t surf,” Barney explained.

“Well then, new tactic. Let the owners of the video game companies know this is happening and if they want to design some gear especially for our new recruit, they can do so for a hefty fee. Branding isn’t free, after all.”

“I’m not sure that will work,” Donald said. It was the first time he’d found his voice since the introductions. Everything that had happened throughout the day was so overwhelming; he was halfway running on autopilot. “I’ve tried to just code items before, but it doesn’t work. For whatever reason, they have to be a piece of a game world, though I’ve got no idea why it would matter.”

“Best not to overthink these things,” Apollo said, waving his hand as if he dismissed such issues every day. “Our powers themselves are often a mystery at the outset; the deeper you dig, the more confusing things get. So, only real game items will work then. I feel like we can still make something happen there, but let’s table it for the moment. Instead, let’s focus on getting you equipped, Donald. Barney, what’s the turnaround on getting a portable unit for our new man, one preprogrammed with every video game and item screen on the market?”

“We could get a halfway decent version in a few days, but if you want something top-of-the-line, we’ll have to wait for Professor Quantum to make it,” Barney replied. “And you know his turnaround times.”

“Order the weaker one as a stop-gap measure; it’ll have to do until we can get Professor Quantum to work on something besides his pet projects,” Apollo instructed. He glanced at Donald and offered up a comforting smile. “The man is a legendary genius, and like most people with that sort of intellect, he’s prone to getting caught up in his research. I’ll talk to Quorum and see if he can’t speed things along. In the meantime, someone schedule Donald a meeting with our costume people. He’ll need some protection while he’s learning the ropes.”

“Already got him booked for tomorrow morning,” Jessica said, hands still whizzing across the keyboard. “The press is hounding us for a name, though. You know how these things go; if we don’t give them something soon, they’ll start using a nickname and it’ll be hell to unstick it from him.”

“How can we forget the way Cuddle Monster got his name?” Apollo let out a sigh as he shook his head, and even Jessica and Barney’s smiles dimmed significantly. “I suppose that means picking a name is the next item on the agenda. Donald, you have my sincere apologies. Normally, we allow our new members to have their names researched and market tested before making them settle on one, but this is a downside to having a debut like yours: things just move faster. Now, you’ve obviously been training on using your abilities for some time now. Have you given any thought to what you might call yourself?”



Donald had, in fact, given a tremendous amount of thought to that ever since he realized the storm had given him powers. However, he'd thought about it in the same way he thought about what he would tell his online friends if he managed to score a supermodel girlfriend: it was always more fantasy than actual problem. Yet here he was, sitting across from Apollo, *the* Apollo, being asked what the name he'd use when he donned his costume would be. It was so far beyond what he'd ever considered possible that it was surreal. Donald kept expecting to wake up suddenly or find out he'd died in the fight. It was taking all he had to keep his sanity together, so the words that popped out of his mouth did so without bothering to get his brain's approval. They knew the brain had bigger issues to deal with.

"I sort of thought... maybe... something like Cyber Geek? You know, turn an insult into a positive, and since my powers relate to digital stuff, I thought it would be cool..." Donald trailed off as he registered the vacant stares from Jessica and Barney. Apollo, however, clapped his hands together so loudly it startled everyone in the room.

"Cyber Geek, huh? I like it! Not too stuffy or proud, a very down-to-earth name. Shows you know where you come from. The Internet is going to love you. Jessica, any issues?"

"Oh, um, one second." She clacked away on the keyboard, pulling up several databases and punching his proposed name into each one. "No prior claims on it, no trademark issues, and nothing in private domain. If he wants Cyber Geek, it would be his free and clear."

"Handling his own debut and picking a name we don't have to pay for; Donald, I am liking you more by the second." Apollo stood from the table and motioned for Donald to do the same, though neither Jessica nor Barney were given such orders. "You two get it registered. I want that name released to the media in the next hour before they try and give him one. As for you, Donald, with the paperwork out of the way, how about I show you around the facilities? The Alliance of Heroic Champions has top-notch gyms, spas, recreation areas, and housing, should you decide to avail yourself of any of that. All of it's here at your disposal to help you be the best superhero you can be."

Donald allowed himself to be led from the room, still uncertain of what, if anything, to say. Apollo seemed to have things well in hand, so Donald let the glowing man keep helping him through the paces. He did wish they'd let him visit Tori and Mr. Gerhardt, though. Assurances were nice, but he'd like to be certain they were okay. Oddly, no one he mentioned it to seemed very worried about them. In fact, if he didn't know better, he'd have said that Apollo was almost annoyed by the mention of Mr. Gerhardt.

He knew he was imagining it, though. Why would a world famous superhero be annoyed by a middle manager?

\* \* \*

"You know, I was coasting on a pretty good wave of respect and self-esteem after last weekend, but then Little Miss Attention had to go and get half the guild talking about her again."

Tori looked up from the sandwich she'd been eating—her third one since leaving her room—to find Beverly standing in the door of the lounge. Ivan had told her that it was usually only rookies on this floor so her chances of seeing anyone were greatly reduced, but somehow, she'd had a feeling it wouldn't be that simple.

"Maybe step your game up," Tori replied, kicking out an empty plastic chair on the other side of the small table. "Or get a day job where you're likely to be a target of organized thieves."

"I have a day job, thank you very much. I do freelance articles for an online fashion company. Haven't even missed a deadline during all the chaos of turning meta." Beverly stopped by the refrigerator and pulled out a half-empty soda bottle, then took the offered seat across from Tori. "It's weird being in here without Lance playing his games. Too quiet."

"He must have gone to bed early. Apparently we've got a big day ahead of us tomorrow," Tori said, digging into her sandwich. Spending three hours in fire-form had healed up most of her injuries, but as soon as she turned human Tori realized that she'd gone the whole day without eating. With the nausea fading and her stomach back in place, she'd begun throwing food down as quickly as she could get it from the vending machine.

“Lance? Nah, guy’s a night owl. Wait, those eat bugs. Maybe a night wasp or something. Point is, I’m usually up pretty late, and I always turn in before him. More likely he’s hanging out with Arachno Bro, getting mentally pumped for whatever they’re going to throw at us.”

“Not the worst idea.” Tori looked around the lounge, admiring the big screen, vast couch, cushy recliners, game tables, and well-stocked vending machines. It seemed like it was made to accommodate far more than just the four apprentices that were currently being trained. She wondered if they’d once had larger groups of recruits, and if so, why that number had dropped off.

“What about Warren? He usually hang out here?” Tori asked.

“Once in a blue moon. Balaam likes to keep him around for training pretty much all the time. People who actually cast magic have it rough; they have to study their asses off to know what they’re doing, otherwise they can accidentally start some serious shit,” Beverly explained. “Not unlike you science types, actually. I’m glad my power is straightforward: turn into dragon, kick ass, turn back.”

“I could have used you on my team today,” Tori admitted. “You never realize how much you need someone who can throw a good punch until you don’t have one.”

“If nothing else, we’re always in demand.” Beverly smirked as she twisted the top off her bottle of soda and drained a quarter of the remaining contents.

“Maybe you should pick up a book on dragon myths,” Tori said. “The flying wyvern, the fire breathing beast, the armored monster; all of your forms seem to be based on popular legends. It might not hurt to see if you can find out what else is in your amulet’s arsenal.”

“Way ahead of you. I’ve read more about dragons in the last month than I ever wanted to know. I even got halfway through a role-playing game manual before I realized there were no actual dragons in it. It’s given me some ideas about what I might be able to do, but try as I might, nothing has come from it. Seems the only way to unlock them is to need them, which is only handy until I get in a situation where the dragon I need doesn’t exist.”

“That’s what you have friends for.” Tori finished off her sandwich and walked right over to the machine to get another. Her stomach was quieter now but far from satisfied.

“I don’t think every hurdle we face is going to be like last week’s trial,” Beverly said.

Tori stuck a wrinkled dollar in the machine and made her selection, peeling back the cellophane as soon as she’d gotten the well-made morsel into her hungry hands.

“Maybe not, but this place runs on teamwork more than you’d think,” Tori replied, returning to the table. “And trust me: if there’s one thing today demonstrated, it’s the importance of having good people watching your back. If it had just been me and Pseudonym, our covers would have been blown and our coworkers might have been killed.”

“Or you could have both played along and just let the robbery happen,” Beverly countered.

A grin that had nothing to do with her sandwich crossed Tori’s face. “Now, I think you know there’s no chance that could have happened. Pseudonym didn’t become known as a villain because of his willingness to take people’s bullshit.”

Beverly leaned back in her plastic chair, looking at Tori appraisingly as she devoured her fourth, and not final, piece of dinner. “And what about you?”

“What do you think? I *am* his apprentice, after all.”

\* \* \*

“Uncle Ivan!” The small girl barreled into Ivan’s legs with such ferocity it might have knocked him off-balance had she been several tons heavier. Her arms curled around his legs, hugging him in the unashamed way that only children ever seem to manage. It was a tragedy that humanity lost that skill as it grew older—perhaps the world might have been a better place if everyone were so free with their affection.

“Good to see you, too.” He reached down and mussed her mousy brown hair with his free hand, the other laden with bags from a nearby restaurant. At his touch, she hugged his legs tighter. Ivan made no move to pull her away.

“That’s enough, Penelope. You have to let Ivan go if he’s going to make it in the door.” From down the hall, Helen stepped into view. A lovely woman in her mid-twenties, she looked only a few years younger than Ivan, though both of them were keenly aware of just how deceiving appearances could be. “Oh, for the love of—I told you that you didn’t have to bring dinner.”

“It was the least I could do after not stopping by for so long.” Ivan took a step forward as Penelope released her grip on him. He shut the house’s bright red door behind him. It looked a touch out of place with the rest of the white exterior, but Helen had never been a woman who shied away from standing out.

“Then it’s an apology meal, is it? In that case, I hope you picked up the little cakes I like.” Helen met him halfway down the hall, gripping Ivan in a hug of her own. It was not as honest and open as Penelope’s, but in her firm embrace was a familiarity and tenderness that spoke to how much had passed between them. “Seriously though, do you have to get attacked at your office before you can free up the time for a visit? Because I still know some people...”

“It’s more that I’ve had a houseguest who has made it impossible to slip away,” Ivan replied. Their hug ended and he made his way into the kitchen, setting the bags down on the island and beginning to unpack them.

“You can bring them along; I don’t mind meeting new people.” Helen hopped onto one of the stools around the island and swept a long strand of her brown hair away as she watched Ivan work. “Though I’m shocked you actually know someone you’re willing to let stay with you.”

Ivan’s voice fell a few octaves, quiet enough that Penelope, who was still ambling about near his legs, wouldn’t hear. “I didn’t. My houseguest is a new intern at my job... at both of my jobs. Which is why I’ve made sure to keep her as far from here as possible.”

Helen's eyebrows shot up and she leaned back in her stool. "Whoaaaa. *You* took an apprentice?"

"Mommy, what's an apprentice?" Penelope asked from down near her mother's feet.

Helen reached down and scooped her daughter up, setting the girl on her lap to be part of the conversation. "An apprentice is like a student, but the teacher is only teaching them instead of a whole class. Mommy is surprised because Uncle Ivan always swore up and down that he'd never take one."

"Why not?" Penelope leaned forward, staring at Ivan with unabashed curiosity. "He helps teach me stuff when he comes over. He's good at it."

"Uncle Ivan just never thought he had anything worth teaching someone enough to have a full-time student," Ivan replied. "And he didn't exactly take this one easily. There were... circumstances."

"Must have been some pretty interesting circumstances," Helen replied. "This apprentice of yours, they someone I should keep an eye out for?"

"Highly unlikely. She's smart, shouldn't do anything to stir up trouble." Even as he said the words, Ivan found himself doubting them. Tori was bright, that much was undeniable, but she also had a genuine talent for putting herself right in the thick of all manner of chaos.

"If you're teaching her, she's got to be something of a sparkplug." Helen lowered Penelope back to the ground as she got restless, allowing the six-year-old to dart about once more. "Got a lot longer left on her apprenticeship?"

"Only a couple of weeks," Ivan said, pulling out a Styrofoam bowl of gumbo and popping off the lid. "In fact, I slipped out tonight because she's going to spend the weekend learning about how to job hunt."

"Wow, she really is near the end then." Not bothering to be even marginally polite, Helen reached into a white paper bag, pulled out a loaf of bread, tore a piece off and dipped it in the gumbo. "My old place has a class

of recruits just about ready for their debuts too. These things always seem to move in cycles.”

“That they do. Anyway, in a few weeks, my home will be my own again and I’ll stop being so elusive.”

“I guess it’s forgivable,” Helen relented. “You’re just trying to keep us secret, so I won’t hold it against you. Assuming...”

Ivan sighed, then reached into the bag and pulled out a large box. Opening it up, he revealed half a dozen mini-cakes topped with chocolate icing.

Helen let out a slight squeal of happiness and clapped her hands together, a joyful outburst that immediately drew Penelope back to her side.

“I’ll give you this, Ivan. It took a while, but you finally learned how to make a proper apology.”

## Chapter 37

“Insecticide?”

Lance frowned at Beverly, an unnatural appearance on his usually cheerful face. “That’s what you call something that kills insects. Completely the opposite of what I do.”

“Well, you didn’t like Bug Lord,” Tori pointed out.

“It’s not that I didn’t *like* Bug Lord, it’s just that it seemed a bit ostentatious for me,” Lance protested. “I’m a simple man. I’d like to have a simple code name.”

Tori, Beverly, and Lance were all sitting on the couch in their floor’s lounge while Warren stood near the entrance. They’d been given directions to gather there that morning, though with no indication of what would follow. It was a setup they were all getting quickly accustomed to, so rather than spend their time fretting over what was to come, they’d begun discussing what code names they would submit to the guild.

“Simple is overrated. I’m going with a classic: Bahamut, king of the dragons,” Beverly declared.

“Not to be ‘that guy’ or anything, but you’re, um, more queen than king,” Lance stammered out slowly.

“Somehow I highly doubt anyone is going to be checking my dragon-form to see if it’s got a scaly cock and balls dangling down there,” Beverly shot back. “Besides, I want people to make the wrong assumptions about who might be behind the dragon’s form. If I ever do slip up and get the capes looking for me, it’ll be all the better if they’re searching for the wrong sex.”

“Damn, that’s pretty smart.” Tori set her hand against her chin, adding the idea to the possibilities already swirling around in her head. “I’ll have to keep that in mind.”



“If this leads to someone suggesting I go by Queen Bee, let me save you the trouble: no, and it’s already in use,” Lance said.

The sound of heavy, clanking footsteps silenced their conversation. All three scrambled up from the couch. Several long moments stretched out, and then at last the familiar helmeted head of Doctor Mechanical came into view from the doorway. He scanned the room, ensuring all four apprentices were present, and then motioned for them to come forward.

“Today, you will all be allowed into a secure area of the guild. Understand this: most of where you’ve been are recreational areas, open freely to all members, regardless of status. That will not be the case where we are headed. Only full members in good standing can proceed to this area. It is a place with secure, dangerous information, and I expect you all to behave appropriately. Be silent unless you have a question, and listen hard. This is where you’ll truly learn how our guild functions.”

Without another word, Doctor Mechanical spun on his heel and headed out of the lounge. Everyone fell silently into line behind him, keeping a respectful distance yet never dropping behind as he made his way through the winding hallways. Soon, he took a set of stairs down three levels, and then walked over to a large wall with a single hole in it. Producing a device from the machinery around his right finger, Doctor Mechanical inserted it into the opening, and moments later, the wall slid away to reveal a wide, spacious elevator.

They piled in, with Doctor Mechanical removing his odd key and stepping in last. There were no buttons to press; the door merely slid closed once more and the elevator began to move downward. There were no windows—only metal walls enclosed them as they moved lower, farther than the bottom floor of the building could possibly be.

“This elevator is the only way in or out of where we’re heading,” Doctor Mechanical informed them. “It’s made to contain and neutralize all but the most powerful of meta-humans. Should an unauthorized person gain entry, it will immediately immobilize and defuse the threat. If the threat cannot be contained—remember that I did say it could only stop *most* metas—then the area below us will be completely destroyed, including, unfortunately, any personnel who happen to be down there. Remember,

above all else, the safety of the guild is paramount. If evidence of what we do were ever uncovered, it would ruin the organization as a whole. Compared to that, a few lives are a smaller cost to pay.”

No one objected to his analysis of the situation, even as they grew nervous about the fact that they would soon be in such a place. The guild had its own ways, after all.

Slowly, the elevator came to a smooth halt, and the door opened once more. Stretched out before them was a long metallic hallway, filled with cameras, lasers, and all manner of odd devices that not even Tori could puzzle out the use for. Doctor Mechanial wasted no time, stepping forward into the room without so much as crooking a finger in their direction. They all took the message anyway and hurried to keep pace behind the metal-suited man.

“Here, every person entering is scanned on multiple levels, ensuring that they are indeed a member of this guild with permission to be here. Everything from their fingerprints to the very strands of their DNA are evaluated. We have no shortage of wards and special cameras to detect trickery. For today, your respective genetic signatures have been given authorization. This will not be the case again unless you prove yourselves worthy of full membership. As you can imagine, those who try to gain unauthorized entry are dealt with in all manner of unpleasant ways, most of them quite permanent. And, as before, should those measures fail, everything beyond here will be purged.”

His heavy steps echoed off the metal floor as he walked, yet Doctor Mechanial’s voice overwhelmed them as it rang clearly through the air. Everyone followed, some with tensed nerves as they waited for an unseen trap to spring out and attack them. Eventually, they reached the end of the hallway where a large but simple metal door awaited them. Doctor Mechanial reached forward, pressed a small button at the side, and stood back as it began to open.

“We tried to think of a good term for this place, something unassuming that still conveyed the importance of it. Sadly, the more theatrical among our ranks won sway over the vote. Nonetheless, it is with

no small amount of pride that I introduce you, Apprentices, to the guild's inner nerve center. Welcome to Sanctum."

\* \* \*

There was a small knock on the door of the room. Well, not *the* room. *His* room. Apollo had showed Donald to it the night before, explaining that his very public debut meant it wasn't safe for Donald to go home just yet. At best, as a public persona he would be hounded by the press for the next few weeks, and at worst the people he helped stop might have friends that wanted payback. His room in the AHC headquarters was nice, a bit like a hotel room in one of the places that tried to replicate apartments. They'd stocked the fridge and brought over some of his clothes, which made getting dressed that morning less stressful. Given that he was in a strange place with his whole life turned upside down, nothing was without at least a little stress, though.

Donald opened his door before the third knock, nearly leaping backward in shock at the creature before him. It looked like someone had hurled a half-dozen killer animals into a genetic blender in the hopes of putting all their muscles, scales, and claws into one body.

The thing in front of him seemed unsurprised by his reaction, waiting patiently until Donald seemed a bit more composed. "Morning." Its voice was thick and rough, the sort of sound one might hear in a nightmare just before waking and staring wide-eyed around a darkened room. "My name is Ren Tanaka. Apollo asked me to come down and get you for your fitting."

"R-right," Donald stammered out. "I mean, sorry, nice to meet you. I'm Donald, Donald Moss." Donald began to stick his hand out for the customary handshake, an impulse so ingrained in him by years of corporate schmoozing that his arm was halfway in position before he realized that Ren might accidentally shred his hand as easily as shake it. Still, by that point, it was too late to pull away without seeming rude. Donald steeled his nerves and finished the gesture, trusting Ren to have the necessary control of his abilities.

"Nice to meet you." Ren easily shook Donald's hand without leaving him with so much as a scratch. "And don't worry about jumping,

most people do far worse the first time they see me. At least you didn't scream."

"If I'm being honest, it was touch and go for a second there." No sooner had the words left his mouth than Donald wished he could yank them back in. Curse his stupid, nervous tongue! He readied himself to apologize again, but before he had the chance, he noticed a deep rumbling coming from Ren's chest, like a cat's purr mixed with a soft bark. It took him a moment to put the pieces together, but eventually logic prevailed and Donald realized that Ren was laughing.

"Nice to meet someone who doesn't tiptoe around all of... this." Ren gestured to all the misshapen strange bits of who he now was. "Most of the other rookies are too put off to even be around me, let alone actually discuss the fact that I look like something out of a bad *Island of Dr. Moreau* knockoff."

"I'd say it's far too well-designed to be a mere knockoff. You're a penny dreadful of your own, if you're anything." Donald had no idea what he was saying, but the large, sharp-toothed grin on Ren's face grew wider, so he assumed things were going well. Or he was about to get eaten. With that expression, things could really go either way.

"Dreadful is going to be the right word if you're late to costuming. Come on, let's get you down there."

Donald didn't pause to lock his door as he followed Ren down the hall. For one thing, there was nothing inside but a few t-shirts, boxers, and a spare pair of khakis. For another, Apollo had explained how every door was keyed to the person supposed to open it. Made things much easier all around.

"I'm curious... since you're on a different track than me, did they get you a name yet?" Ren asked.

"Excuse me, but different track?"

Ren nodded, an action which sent his fur to waving. "Yeah. You're someone who debuted on his own. Along with training, most of us are still being primed for our debuts; everything will be planned, researched, and

carefully controlled. The AHC likes to start all of its new superheroes on a good public footing.”

“That sounds... so much smarter than what I did.” Donald had imagined showing up on the AHC’s doorstep and being turned away because his ability was so useless. It had never dawned on him that they might have programs up and running specifically to get him up to snuff.

“I don’t know. The longer I’m cooped up in here, the more I wish I’d gotten to do things your way. Jump right into the action, use these powers for something good. Though, without the PR department here managing my debut, people probably would have assumed I was the villain in any situation,” Ren admitted.

“Probably beats some giant smashing on your shield, trying to turn to you into a pulped programmer.” Donald shivered slightly at the thought, quickly steering the conversation back to more pleasant topics. “I do have a name, to answer your question. Picked it out yesterday. I’m going by Cyber Geek.”

“Not too bad.” Ren thrust a clawed thumb into his own chest. Only his scales kept him from piercing his sternum. “They’re calling me Medley.”

“Medley, you say?” Donald turned the name around in his head, trying to find something positive to say about it. “That’s certainly...”

“Idiotic? Asinine? Flat-out dumb? Don’t worry, I’m well aware.” Ren shrugged his massive shoulders as they turned down a new hallway. “But if I want to help people, they can’t be scared of me. A name like that helps soften my image, at least according to the market research.”

“They market-researched your name? Wow, you weren’t kidding about them going all-out on prepping stuff for your debut,” Donald noted.

“You don’t know the half of it,” Ren said. “And if you’re lucky, you never will. Let’s just say I’ve had my fill of paperwork and image management. I’m ready to get out there and start actually making a difference.”

Donald looked his fellow aspiring superhero up and down, taking in his size and natural defenses. If Ren had been there, the fight with that big meta in the office would have probably gone a lot differently. Then again, if Ren had been there, the robbers probably would have taken one look at him and gone screaming for the hills.

“Is your debut soon?” Donald asked. He had a feeling there would be a lot of criminals watching their shit once Ren took the streets.

“End of this week or the start of the next one,” Ren replied. “Almost everything is in place. Once the last few bits are done, it’s just a matter of waiting for the right crime. They have a fellow member come out with me, just so no one mistakes me for a bad guy, and then let me help save people or stop bad guys. Afterward, there’s a press conference—more or less what you went through.”

“What do you do if there’s no crime?” Donald had lived in Ridge City all his life, and while things could get crazy on occasion, the big incidents were often weeks, if not months, apart. There were only so many metas dumb enough to tangle with the Alliance of Heroic Champions where they lived, after all.

“There’s always crime,” Ren told him. “In a city this size it’s inevitable, and the AHC keeps watch over way more than just Ridge City. Now, not all of it is meta-human crime; in fact, that’s a minority by far, but there’s still enough of it that not even us and the police can stop every petty thief and mugger. We try to prioritize our responses to do the best we can. First priority is meta-humans, obviously. Then come situations where we’re in less danger than normal cops would be. After that is the mundane stuff, just pitching in where we can.”

“Gotcha. Guess I’m going to have to learn about all this,” Donald said.

Ren stopped walking, reached over, and patted Donald carefully on the shoulder. “Don’t sweat it too much. They’ve been training new superheroes in here for decades; they know how to prep us for the real world. Just do your best, and hopefully you won’t make any big screw-ups that get people killed.”

“Well, that’s encouraging,” Donald muttered.

“That’s the gig,” Ren said, giving another giant shrug. “Anyway, this is your stop. Just go through the door behind me and you’ll be whisked into a world of fittings and fabrics. Try and endure it as stoically as possible. Think of it as a rite of passage, if that helps.”

“Did it help you?” Donald asked, grabbing the doorknob and beginning to turn.

“Hell no. But you’ll get through it. And afterwards, we can get some lunch and I’ll introduce you around.”

Donald smiled and nodded. His first full day in the AHC and it seemed like he’d actually managed to make a friend. “I’ll look forward to it.”

## Chapter 38

For three of the four apprentices, what was revealed behind the door was initially anti-climactic. For Tori, whose mind and study had long been devoted to cutting edge technology, Doctor Mechanical might as well have opened the pearly gates and ushered her directly into heaven itself.

In the spacious room were a bevy of devices visibly branching off into several distinct hallways, scattered about as if they weren't technological marvels worthy of being put on display. With a single glance, Tori recognized a spatial anchoring apparatus (meant to stop spatial manipulators like Tunnel Vision from breaking and entering), a quantum entanglement relay (to talk with people over any distance), and what she took to be a cellular recombination machine, or techno-teleporter, which had heretofore had only been discussed on a theoretical level. This was on top of the dozen or so smaller wonders as well as a massive hub of computers.

The remainder of the apprentices entered behind Tori, who was fighting not to sprint ahead of Doctor Mechanical with all her self-control. They turned their attention to the room's natural focal point: a large digital display showing several columns of information.

"This is what we colloquially refer to as 'the job board.'" Doctor Mechanical pointed to the display, more to direct Tori's attention to where the lesson was meant to take place than anything else. "Nothing in this area can be connected to by outside sources, regardless of what powers or tech they're using. Any internet access is run through various hubs that are all set to disconnect the minute anything non-requested tries to come through the system. The reason for all the security is that in here, in this place of safety, we plan and discuss the crimes committed by guild members. The job board is where it all begins and ends."

He moved forward once more, walking down the metal stairs onto the crisp white-tile floor below, followed by the apprentices. Soon they were standing directly beneath the digital display. Now closer, they could



make out that within each of the columns were various listings, each with a title and short description. They could also see that the columns were color-coded: red, yellow, and green.

“When a member of this guild has the idea for a job, they submit it to their council representative for review,” Doctor Mechanical continued. “After it’s been vetted and we’re sure there are no conflicts with the code, it is posted down here on the job board. You can access this feature from any terminal in Sanctum, learning all the details about what’s planned, seeing who has signed on in various capacities, what the expected score is, what roles are still needed... you know what? This probably a lot easier if I just show you a sample.”

Doctor Mechanical waved his metallic hand at the screen, and to their surprise, one of the listings in the red column expanded, filling the entire gigantic display. After reading over it for a minute, he turned back around so that the front of his helmet was facing them.

“That will do nicely. What you see here is a planned robbery of an art house in Madrid. As you can tell at a glance, Pointillism is listed in the ‘Leader’ role, as she’s the one who put this job together. She created the plan, she calls the shots while in the field, and she is entitled to a larger cut of the proceeds. In fact, if you glance below her name, you’ll see she’s offering a fifty-fifty split, where she takes fifty percent of the profits and the other fifty is split equally among the others who do the job. I should note that usually leaders will take a bit less than this, but because Pointillism has a reputation for pulling off flawless jobs, she’s able to demand a bit more of the take.”

A quick crook of the finger from Doctor Mechanical and the screen zoomed in on the section below Pointillism’s name. This area was filled with basic role descriptions, though most of the sections next to them were empty. There were, however, two names gracing the lower list.

“As you can see here, Pointillism needs two people with enhanced strength—roles that Smash and Grab have filled. These three often work together; in fact, Smash and Grab may have been included on the plan submission itself. The other openings on this job are for a teleporter and someone who can hack the computer security. Since this opening just went

up today, I wouldn't at all be surprised if applications have already been submitted. I imagine those roles will be filled before this evening. Like I said before, Pointillism has a reputation for clean plans and solid executions. She only works with good people, and the scores she goes for are usually large. In this case, she's aiming for around twenty million dollars' worth of sculptures."

Everyone could clearly see the giant total on the screen, a mind-boggling amount to most of them. Even with Pointillism taking half, that would work out to two and a half million dollars per person for what seemed like a few days' work, max. Tori suddenly understood why just being in this guild could lead so many into the arms of crime. With only a few jobs like that, she'd have enough seed money to start all the companies she wanted.

"I should also point out that the guild charges a three percent tax on the gains from all jobs here—far less than the government would, but enough to help keep the lights on," Doctor Mechanical added. "As far as being the leader of a job goes, right now you're all no doubt thinking it's a cushy gig. Submit a good plan, approve some competent cohorts, and take home the lion's share of the profits. You should know, however, that being in the leadership role comes with more than just a higher payday: it also means you are the one held accountable if things go awry. I'm not saying the mistakes of others will be laid at your feet, but should a job you pull turn into a problem for us, and especially if the code is broken, then you will be held accountable for that failure. At this point in your training, I trust I don't have to explain what that means."

Doctor Mechanical made a motion and the screen shrank, the three color-coded columns and their accompanying listings having shrunk back to their original size. "Now then. What we just looked at was a red job, meaning it was illegal and came with serious risk for all those involved. That's not the only way to apply our talents, though, which is why there are other colors." He flicked his finger at the screen, and suddenly the middle column grew to dominate the digital space.

"Yellow jobs, as seen in the middle column, are jobs that, while often criminal adjacent, pose a low risk of arrest. We often get requests to arrange transportation for people that wish to move about unseen by law

enforcement, to provide a bodyguard for an unstable and illegal situation, or to obscure unscrupulous bank transactions. Those requests are received by our people tasked with such work, and those we accept go in the yellow column.”

Another motion and the final column became the largest on the screen. “Green jobs are ones that occur within the guild itself. Maybe someone needs help getting rid of some scrapped robots or a councilor wants a new assistant. These are done for a fair wage, which is specified in the listing. Since this is a guild of villainy, there is always the chance that taking a green job will result in light criminal activity, but it should never be anything too extreme.”

Spiel complete, Doctor Mechanicall allowed the display to go back to its default setting. He carefully examined the faces of the apprentices before him to make sure they had absorbed the information. It wasn’t that complicated; in fact, the council had worked hard to keep things exceedingly simple. But the system was deeper than it seemed on first glance. Having to assess jobs, both the risks they carried and the rewards they offered, took a lot of practice, and that was without even factoring in the skills of the people one would be working alongside. This would be the bread and butter of their activities in the guild, unless they all made a beeline for Ivan’s department, which was doubtful. It was hard to walk away once those dollar signs danced in front of one’s eyes.

“This will, of course, all come to you assuming you prove yourselves worthy to be members of this guild. To achieve that, we will spend the rest of the weekend on more training, but we won’t be stopping there. For the next two weeks, you will be shadowing guild members on jobs, sometimes in mock situations, sometimes in real ones. At the end of that time, you four will be expected to put together a job of your own. Think of it as a demonstration of skill.”

Though she’d known it was coming, Tori still pretended to reel a bit like the others. Ivan had been right; they truly were coming to the end of their time as apprentices. Soon it would be all or nothing, and she could scarcely wait. When the time came, she had no intention of coming up short.

Especially if she had her meta-suit ready.

\* \* \*

“All right, sorry about that. The fire is more or less under control, so we can get back to the meeting.”

Professor Quantum’s voice held no signs of distress over the sudden explosion and fire that had come from his side of the call. Others might have been more surprised by his calm demeanor, but after years of working alongside one another, Quorum and Lodestar knew to take such things in stride. As a being with nigh-incomparable intellect and almost unstoppable physical powers, Professor Quantum simply did not rattle easily.

“Glad to hear it. I hope none of your assistants were injured,” Quorum said. He sat alone in the conference room with only the remote relays used by the Congress’s two other members to keep him company. It had been this way for years now. First Lodestar had taken her leave, then Professor Quantum had begun spending more and more time in that island lab of his. It didn’t bother Quorum from a social perspective—alone was one of the few things he could never feel—but it certainly didn’t do much to help the other members feel looked after. That was, in fact, the point of the day’s meeting, and why Apollo hadn’t been asked to sit in on it.

“Where were we?” Professor Quantum asked.

“Quorum was making the case that one of us should officially resign our post and let the new kid take up the slack,” Lodestar informed him.

“Apollo has been with the AHC for nearly a decade now. He’s one of the most popular, respected members of our organization and has worked hard to learn every aspect of how things are run,” Quorum replied. “He is anything but ‘the new kid’ by any measurement. I believe it will do the others good to see him move up to the Champions’ Congress. Absentee overseers are not helpful for morale.”

“Personally, I never much cared for the boy,” said Professor Quantum. “Too overt with his ambitions. He’s blatantly had his sights set on a Congress seat since almost the first day he was brought in. I believe

those on the Congress should be able to conduct themselves with a bit more discretion.”

“If this kid’s worst sin is wanting to take on a hard, thankless job and working his way toward it, then maybe he does deserve a shot.” Lodestar and Professor Quantum disagreed almost by tradition at this point, though she had always tended to be the one to give people the benefit of the doubt.

“Apollo is not perfect,” Quorum said. “That can also be said about any of us. Yes, he is ambitious and poor at hiding it. He also puts on a show of constant cheer and encouragement to keep up a positive image, despite having as wide a range of emotion as any of us. He is young and brash and sometimes a bit too quick to jump to battle when talking could work. However, he has great potential and the desire to serve this Congress well. Better to bring him in now, flaws and all, so that he can have two experienced members to learn under. If we ever intend to pass the reins of the AHC to the next generation, this is a necessary first step we’ll one day have to take.” Many of the voices in his head were already correcting Quorum’s words, but he ignored them. This was the decision that he’d made, and he would see it through.

Silence stretched across the untold distances while his fellow superheroes, founders of the very organization tasked with helping to keep the world safe from rogue meta-humans, pondered what would be best for the AHC’s future. All of them had the ability, or curse, to live long lives, but if they never relinquished leadership, then eventually the AHC would atrophy. Fresh blood, new perspective, those things were essential to keeping an organization moving forward. They all knew this, had discussed this, yet still it was hard for any of them to let go of what they’d worked so hard to build, even a little bit.

“He can have my spot,” Lodestar said at last. “At least on a trial basis. I’ll still listen in and check up on things, but if he can show me that he’s really got what it takes, then we can do the full hand-off and make things official. Quorum’s right: our people need to see their leaders putting in the work just like them. Since I can’t do that anymore, the best thing for me to do is find someone who can.”

“We will be sad to see you go,” Professor Quantum told her. “Perhaps I’ll even arrange a trip to Ridge City so I can attend a few of these meetings in person with Apollo. In a few months, when my schedule relents, of course.”

“Of course,” Quorum said. “We all know how busy you are.”

“Busy and productive,” Professor Quantum replied. “Come this time next year, I daresay I’ll have quite the interesting package to send your way.”

“I’ll look forward to that. In the meantime, I’ll bring Apollo in and let him know that he’s officially to begin training for replacing Lodestar on the Champions’ Congress. We’ll keep it private for now until everything is official; although, I’ll need to upgrade his security clearances if we’re going to teach him to do the work,” Quorum said.

“I know you’ll take him down to the vault, but try and keep him from touching the pleasure orb we took from that alien with the nineteen heads and fire breath,” Lodestar cautioned. “Unless he has willpower like iron, he’ll be down for a week at least, and then you’ll have to get his mind purged of the memory or he’ll be addicted.”

“Please also instruct him that the ancient device we uncovered south of Egypt is to be looked at, not touched,” Professor Quantum added. “I do not have time to undo another rip in dimensional space that allows dinosaurs to come stomping about.”

“I assure you both, we will observe full safety protocol when touring every bit of the restricted areas, including the vault,” Quorum promised. “Now, if there are no more objections, I will go fetch Apollo and we can give him the good news.”

“Go for it,” Lodestar replied, her voice present even as her body and mind sat elsewhere, pondering the idea of truly stepping out of the AHC. “We might as well get this over with.”

## Chapter 39

Sunday evening found Ivan waiting patiently for Tori, as well as cleaning the kitchen while he had the opportunity. Since Wade had arranged for the robotic cars to drop her off at the end of the weekend, it meant a bit more alone time for Ivan. With the kids at their mother's and his apprentice undergoing training, the weekend had been the first real bit of peace he'd gotten in weeks. This was how it used to be before Wade showed up talking about a stubborn woman who needed guidance. It was a calm, measured, safe existence. It was what Ivan had fought so hard to obtain all those years ago, and after two days of it, he was ready to climb the damn walls with boredom.

There was no doubt where the blame for this shift in attitude lay; it was unquestionably Tori's fault. She'd been dragging him back into the guild's world a bit at a time, whetting his appetite for intrigue and adventure. Ivan felt like a long-sober alcoholic who'd accidentally taken a sip of vodka. The cravings he'd thought were gone came surging back through his brain as if it were the first day all over again. Once upon a time, his hunger for excitement, chaos, and battle had led him to take on every cape he came across. Now older and wiser, Ivan didn't quite feel the urge to charge up the AHC's front door and pick a fight, but he also wasn't quite as content with cleaning the kitchen as he once might have been.

A slam from the front door echoed through the house, signaling that his apprentice had arrived at last. Ivan stepped out from the kitchen, dishtowel still in hand, just in time to catch Tori making a beeline for the secret entrance to the basement. She looked weary—a weekend of guild training would do that to nearly anyone—but there was excitement burning in her eyes as she rushed toward the bookshelf.

“Not even a hello?” Ivan said, watching his apprentice carefully.

“Hi, how's it going? Life good? Family healthy? Nice catching up, then, talk to you later.” Tori spat the words out as quickly as she could,

racing all the faster for the hidden doorway now that she knew Ivan was trying to stop her.

“Freeze,” Ivan commanded. To her credit, Tori immediately complied, though her eyes never really looked away from her destination for more than a few seconds. “What’s the rush to get down to the basement?”

“What do you think the rush is?” Tori replied. “I’ve got two weeks until we’re supposed to pull a job to prove we can get into the guild, a job which will literally have my life on the line. I need to get my meta-suit in working order by then; otherwise, I’m going into yet another situation with a hand tied behind my back.”

“Most people would consider your powers advantage enough,” Ivan pointed out.

“Maybe so, but most people can’t build what I can build, so they don’t have a good perspective.” Tori nodded to the wall, her whole body leaning slightly forward in excitement. “Now, I’ve spent all my downtime this weekend planning how to get it up and running with the little windows I’ll have to work in between the office and the night training, so can I please go get in some work before my whole plan goes to shit?”

“You can if you really want to. My apologies for holding you up,” Ivan said. He watched as she bolted over to the wall, but before she could trigger the door, he spoke again. “I just thought I’d tell you that we’re both going to have next week off from the office.”

“Waaaait, who the what now?” Tori’s hand paused halfway to the door’s opening device, unable to continue forward. “Why are we off? People knew we were getting transported to a place with fancy metas as doctors.”

Ivan set the kitchen towel on the living room table and took a seat. Though he made no gestures and said nothing, seconds later Tori walked over to join him. Now that she knew there would be more time to work, her curiosity was winning out over her drive to jump into the basement.



“Yes, we will make much faster recoveries than anyone would expect without meta involvement,” Ivan assured her. “However, particularly in situations like the ones you and I found ourselves in, a weekend is too short a time to return to work. Assuming our physical injuries could be healed that quickly, which is suspect for people as unimportant as we are supposed to be, there’s also the mental health issue. We were both attacked. I was shot, and you had your ribs broken. As the nice, normal office workers we’re supposed to be, don’t you think we might need a little bit of time to emotionally process all of that?”

“Right... I sort of forget we’re not supposed to be badassess,” Tori admitted.

“It’s the kind of small detail that on its own might slip by unnoticed, but if enough of its kind accumulate, someone could put things together.” Ivan gently tapped the table, making sure he had his apprentice’s attention. “When you’re on your own, if you choose to keep this civilian identity, that sort of attention to detail will help you last a lot longer.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.” There was no sarcasm in her tone; after fighting so hard to retain her secret only days before, she’d begun to realize how important her mundane life was. It was a place to get away from the madness of the guild, something that gave her perspective on the world and how things were supposed to work. Among people with tremendous power and flexible morality, it was easy to lose sight of what things were like in the real world. “So, what’s the story, anyway? Are we spending the week in the loony bin?”

“We’re undergoing counseling, which will continue after we return to work,” Ivan told her. “The guild will falsify all the necessary paperwork and doctor’s notes, which no one will question because right now, the management views us as both heroes and potential lawsuits.”

Tori leaned back in her chair, not quite so far that she risked tipping but enough to stretch her tired back. “That’s so nice of them, considering I got shot in the arm four times.”

“To be fair, you did that to yourself,” Ivan reminded her.

“Yeah, well, Chloe’s power isn’t the easiest to work with. Speaking of, can I go check on her at some point? I know you said she’s okay, but given how much she helped, I feel like I owe her a face-to-face.”

“Chloe is doing well, though she’s actually going to be taking the week off and getting some counseling, too, just to make certain she’s all right,” Ivan said. “And don’t worry; we’re footing the bill for her treatment as well. You can check in on her next week, when you’re both supposed to be back at work.”

“Guess that will help sell the story all the more.” Tori rose from the table, waiting for Ivan to stop her. When nothing came, she turned toward the wall, mind already intent on the basement. “You’re really good at keeping up the act, I have to say. One day, I’m going to get you tell me why you really decided to hang up the costume and go mundane.”

“Was the offer of freedom coupled with the fact that the world was ending not a believable reason?” Ivan asked.

“Back then, sure, but we’ve been at this for a while now. I’ve gotten to know you pretty well, and you’re a stubborn guy. For you to have completely turned over a new leaf, to commit as hard to this as you did, I know there’s something else at play.”

For the second time that night, Tori was nearly to the basement entrance when Ivan’s words stopped her dead in her tracks.

“I’ll trade you.”

“Trade me what?”

“The truth. The whole story of why I took the offer, why I adhered to the Orion Protocol. In exchange, I want you to tell me why you’re so dead-set on living the way you have. With a brain like yours, you could have gotten a job at any tech company in the world. With powers like yours, there was never any need for a meta-suit. Yet you keep on pushing, taking the hardest path possible. So I’m up for a trade, if you’re amenable to the terms.”

Ivan sat still at the table, patiently waiting for a reply. He wasn’t pressuring her or forcing her hand, merely making an offer: tit-for-tat,

information for information.

“Seems to me like you’re asking for more than you’re offering.” Tori turned around slowly, locking eyes with her teacher. “I think I can fill in a lot of the gaps for myself on your story; all I’m seeking is details. You, on the other hand, are asking for some pretty personal shit.”

“Is this you saying no?”

“This is me saying sweeten the pot,” Tori replied. “A trade is only fair if it’s equal.”

Ivan turned this over in his head a few times, debating on what he was willing to offer to know his apprentice’s secrets. He’d found out much on his own through research, but there was a large difference between reading a file and hearing a person tell a story. So much more could be learned from the latter that the two were hardly even worth comparing. Of course, that was just as true for him as it was for her, which meant he had to be careful how much of his own past he gave away.

“I will tell you the root of my power,” Ivan said. “Not the story of how I acquired it or any useful details regarding how it works, however. Truthfully, this will leave you with more questions than answers, but it’s still something precious few people know. If that isn’t good enough, then I suppose we don’t have a deal.”

“No, I think that’ll do. But you’re going first.” Tori walked past Ivan into the freshly cleaned kitchen and pulled a cold beer from the fridge. Much as she liked to be clear-headed when she worked, this sort of talk called for at least a little liquid fortification.

“Only for the first part. My power, we save for last, otherwise you’ll want to ask me more questions instead of offering up your story,” Ivan countered, calling through the doorway.

Halfway back, Tori stopped, reopened the fridge, and poured a tall glass of sweet tea for Ivan. He might want a little fortification of his own, after all. Gripping both drinks, Tori walked back into the living room, set the tea down in front of Ivan, and retook her seat.

“I guess that’s fair,” Tori said at last.

Ivan reached out and took hold of the glass, treating himself to a long sip of the cold beverage before he began to speak. “I’m sure you know Lodestar was the one who finally brought me in, got me locked away in Rookstone with the other criminal meta-humans. We fought several times, but I always managed to get away when she had the upper hand. I was convinced I could beat her if I only had the right strategy, could build up enough power. When the day of our last fight came, I gave it everything I could manage. All my power, all my strength, every tactic and trick I could conceive of, and it just flat-out wasn’t enough. She beat me, defeated me in a way I’d never experienced before. Now, much as that sounds like the start of a story of lifelong vengeance, it’s hard not to have some amount of respect for an opponent like that. I guess she felt the same way—there weren’t many metas who could challenge her—because even after hauling me off to jail, she would still visit from time to time.”

“Wait, you and Lodestar hung out together?” Tori didn’t exactly doubt the story, but she was definitely having trouble wrapping her head around it.

“Think of it more as community outreach. Lodestar believed that there was potential in me, that I could be more than a battle-thirsty punk. Of course, she saw the good in everyone, so it wasn’t that surprising, but even now, I think she took a special interest in me. Maybe she really did see something, or maybe she just knew the day might come when she needed an ally like me. Anyway, once Orion turned into a cataclysmic threat, she was the one they sent to talk to me, to make me the offer.”

“Damn. I was not expecting it to be friendship with Lodestar that turned you around.” Tori sipped at her beer, entranced by the story but keenly aware that her turn was fast approaching.

“It wasn’t,” Ivan told her. “When Lodestar showed up that day, she didn’t come empty-handed. She brought along a picture of a baby, only a few months old at the time, and put it down on the table in front of me. I’d slept with a woman who had a thing for bad boys before Lodestar brought me in, and, well... I wasn’t making the best decisions back then, ideas about protection included. When Lodestar made the pitch, she didn’t lean on the part where I’d have a shot at freedom. Instead, she just showed me the picture and explained how things were. Orion was trying to destroy the

world and every living creature on it. One of those creatures, as it turned out, was my son.”

Ivan paused, looking down at the glass in his hand, drops of condensation running down the side, one at a time. “I don’t expect you to understand. Up until that moment, I don’t think I possibly could have either, but there’s something primal about being a parent. Something powerful. Suddenly, Orion wasn’t just some threat trying to wipe out existence. He was threatening my family, my blood. As soon as Lodestar showed me that photo, I knew I would charge the very gates of hell if it meant keeping that baby safe. That’s why I took the deal. That’s why I tried so hard to honor it, too. Even gave it an honest go with his mother, which is how his sister came about. We live in a strange, powerful, dangerous world. I decided I would be there to watch over my children, even if it meant setting aside the life I’d known until then. Fornax died the moment I knew I was a father, though I did borrow his name one last time to end Orion.”

“Shit. I suspected it had something to do with your kids, but I didn’t imagine it went down quite like that,” Tori admitted. “Pretty shrewd of Lodestar to save her trump card until she needed it.”

Ivan chuckled and shook his head. “Lodestar doesn’t think that way. She never told me about my son because she thought it would be cruel; I was in a place where I could never see him, never talk to him, never hug him. It wasn’t until there was a chance for my freedom that she decided to tell me.”

“Guess that morality is why you just trusted she wasn’t making it all up,” Tori said.

“That, and a few talents of my own.” Ivan took a draw from his tea and stared at Tori. He didn’t bother telling her that it was her turn; that much was obvious. Instead, he let her get her thoughts together and speak when she was ready.

“My story isn’t as long or fancy as yours,” she said at last. “It’s just a hard life lesson I learned early on. My parents were both scientists—Dad a biologist and Mom a physicist. They worked hard, gave me a solid education from the day I was born, nurtured my mental talent as soon as they recognized it. Both of them had such high hopes for me. Then, one day

there was an accident at the lab where they worked. Might have been a confluence, actually, since more than a few people left that day as metas. My parents weren't among them."

The air around Tori shimmered softly as she spoke, and her grip on the beer bottle tightened. Ivan knew how hard she'd been working to gain control of her emotions affecting her powers, which made it all the more worrying to see the heat slipping out.

"They just got sick. Bad sick. Like a meta-version of cancer. It ripped through them so fast. In only a couple of weeks, they were so filled with tumors... well, you get the idea. There were treatment options, of course. With all the metas in the world, there's always someone who can fix what ails you, be it by spell or machine or just talent, but those options are impossibly expensive. And the company they worked for, the one who owned the lab that made them sick, refused to pay what it would have cost to save them. Said they'd signed non-liability agreements, that the lab wasn't culpable. They just let my parents sit in that goddamned hospital room and rot away from the inside out."

Tori was crying now—not a full-on sob, but small, short-lived tears that evaporated before they were halfway down her face. Ivan had seen many tears throughout his life, and he knew enough to tell that these were not shed from grief, but from anger.

"I sat there, watching them die by the hour. And in that time, I realized something important: my parents spent their lives working hard to help other people, and when the time for repayment came, those other people skipped out. I wasn't going to go down that path. I would work for myself, make my own way in the world. I'd never be left on a bed, slowly dying because my fate ended up in some corporate asshole's hands. That's why I went out on my own. That's why I decided it was better to scrounge and steal than indenture myself to anyone else."

"You have my condolences," Ivan said simply. There was nothing else to tell her, nothing she didn't already know. It was a tragedy. Had he been there at the time, he'd have done all he could to change it. But it was long over, and not even metas had the power to bring back the dead. "Is that

also why you work so hard on the meta-suit? So you'll be able to live under your own power?"

"That was part of why I started," Tori admitted. "I had to create inventions and that seemed like a good place to kick things off. But, to be honest, I think I really picked up the project as a memorial. My mother loved meta-suits. She believed they could bridge the gap between metas and humans. Everyone who has made one so far has kept the tech all to themselves, which means that if I manage to develop one that anyone can use, I'll be able to launch a huge company and make my mother's dream come true all at once. Double-whammy, you know?"

"Two birds with one stone, indeed." Ivan finished off his tea then rose to go get another glass. By the time he'd returned with a fresh beer that hadn't been nearly boiled, Tori had regained her composure. She accepted the drink with a nod of thanks, taking a long draw before addressing her teacher.

"So, did that satisfy you?"

"It answered many of my questions, yes. And my story?"

"Explained a lot about you," Tori replied. "Though there is one part left unfulfilled. If both of the other parts are done, you owe me an origin story."

"No, I owe you only what the root of my power is," Ivan corrected. "No story, no explanations, only the simple source of my meta-abilities."

"Yeah, I get it, more questions than answers; just get on with it already. I'd still like to squeeze in a little work tonight, if you don't mind."

"Fair enough. My powers come from a magical source—which is no surprise—that I encountered in my youth. While the exact relationship I have with that source has altered tremendously since the beginning, I'd say things have been constant for the last several decades. Explaining that relationship though... how shall I phrase this?" Ivan drummed his fingers, took a drink from his tea, and finally found the right combination of words that suited his needs.

"To put it as simply as possible: I ate a god."

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## Chapter 40

“We’re not doing it tonight,” Morgana said, barely resisting the urge to slam her hand on the table. “That’s their first day, and it’s an imprudent way to start things off. They *do* need to get some actual field training in.”

“Plus, it’s Monday,” Stasis added. Unlike Morgana, she wasn’t taking things too seriously, which was par for the course with how things went when they were both involved. Leaning back in her chair, feet on the table, Stasis might as well have been doing her nails, had she actually been able to do anything to them. Instead, she was skimming through a beat-up romance novel starring a swarthy Latin hero named Rodrigo. “There’s nothing worth doing on a Monday.”

“Well, we can’t do it on the last day. Doc will say they need to have a level head for their upcoming planning session,” Xelas shot back. Next to her, Gork laid a reassuring hand on her metal friend’s shoulder, a simple act that helped keep Xelas’s sharp tongue in check.

“Training runs for two weeks,” Gork said in her slow, lumbering voice. “Let’s do it on the first Friday, the one coming up. It will be a nice break in the middle.”

“Friday works for me,” Stasis said. “That’s when there’s shit actually worth doing.”

“I can swing that, though I’m still not sure I should,” Morgana admitted.

All four of the female councilors were gathered together in a meeting room that was technically only supposed to be used for official crime-planning purposes. Given their high position in the guild, though, they’d commandeered it for their own use without feeling guilty about it in the slightest. There were certain perks to being villains, after all.

“Come on. It’ll be good for the apprentices, and for us,” Xelas said. “When was the last time the four of us all went out to tear up the town?”

“Literally? That incident in Canada a few years back. Figuratively? I feel like it’s only been a little while.” Stasis leaned so far back that her center of gravity should have tipped the chair over, yet she remained supported. “Let’s see, I’d just won my second term on the council, which was... holy shit, it has been a while, hasn’t it?”

“That’s what I’m saying!” Xelas thrust an arm in the air, a gesture either meant to rally the others around her or signal victory; no one was entirely sure which. “We go out in ones and twos on occasion, but we really need to do something together regularly. We’re on the council, we need to bond.”

“If its bonding you’re after, why not invite the guys too?” Stasis asked.

“Because then Balaam would come,” Morgana said, intercepting the question. “And no one considers him and Pseudonym bickering at one another a good time. Plus the dog shtick got tired a long time ago.”

“Bal’s not so bad on his own,” Stasis defended. “But yeah, he does have a stick up his ass when it comes to Pseudonym. Fine: we keep it as a girls’ night, just us four and the two female apprentices.”

“That’s what I like to hear.” Xelas glanced at the plasma television mounted on the conference room’s wall. Seconds later, it turned on and displayed an itinerary on its high-definition screen. “Now that we’ve got the date down, it’s time to decide what we’ll do with them.”

“Let’s try not to get either of them killed, either that night or by expulsion from the guild,” Morgana suggested. “Pseudonym and Thuggernaut are both quite fond of their apprentices, whether they’ll admit it or not.”

“Nothing to worry about,” Xelas assured her. “Truth be told, I sort of like them as well. They’ve got spunk. We’ll keep things nice and low-key, nothing that will get them in trouble.”

The room was quiet as the three other women stared at Xelas. None of them spoke; they simply waited patiently for what would inevitably come next. After having worked together for so long, none were surprised

when a mischievous twinkle sparked through her mechanical eyes and a slight smirk turned up on the side of her lips.

“Well, not *that* much trouble, I mean.”

\* \* \*

When Donald showed up to work that morning, he hadn't been quite sure what to expect. The stares were strange, but that much had been anticipated, along with the whispering. What took him by surprise was the way people gave him a wide berth, doing little more than wave from across the cubicle lanes. He hadn't shown up in costume or with the new wrist computer they'd given him or anything; he'd shown up as regular old Donald Moss, programmer for Vendallia Industries for over five years.

He should have expected something from Apollo's reaction when Donald told him he had to go to work that day. There were too many projects still left undone, and he didn't want to leave his coworkers in the lurch by up and quitting all at once. Plus, he still wasn't entirely sure how superheroes got paid, which made the idea of giving up his income stream a frightening prospect on top of everything else. Apollo had listened, nodded, and then said he would arrange some transportation and protection, just in case someone tried to sneak attack him. That seemed normal enough. What struck Donald as odd, though, was that Apollo had made sure he knew the car would be on call all day: whenever Donald was ready to come back, it was only a phone call away.

He was only halfway to his lunch break, and Donald had already figured out why Apollo drove the point home. This place wasn't the same anymore; people looked at him completely differently. He'd helped keep them all safe, and they did seem appreciative of that, but it didn't change the fact that they were also afraid of him. Donald wasn't just Donald anymore. Now, when they looked at him, what they saw was a meta.

“Mr. Moss? We weren't expecting to see you in today.”

Donald spun around in his chair, slightly startling the suited brunette standing just inside his cube. Mrs. Espinoza was Mr. Gerhardt's boss; she worked on a different floor than they did and usually only showed up for special meetings or when someone was in trouble. Before he could answer

his own question with a little thought, Donald blurted out the first thing that came to mind.

“Where’s Mr. Gerhardt?”

“The hospital, of course,” Mrs. Espinoza replied. “Even with exceptional care, gunshot wounds take some time to recover from, at least for most people. I’m filling in for him while he’s gone.”

“Right.” Right. Mr. Gerhardt would need some time to recover from getting shot in the gut, to say nothing of Tori and all the wounds she’d accumulated helping him. At the thought of Tori, Donald felt a pang of guilt about covering up her help that day. Even if it was to protect Chloe, taking all the credit still felt wrong. “Do you know what hospital they’re at? I’d like to bring flowers and visit, if I can.”

“I’m sorry, since they were taken for... special treatment, we weren’t given the name or location of their hospital. Protected secret, I’m sure you understand.” Mrs. Espinoza looked him up and down once more as if she were waiting for him to grow horns and attack her. Which maybe she was; Apollo had made a point of not telling the press exactly what Donald’s power was until they’d created his identity, so no one in the office had any idea exactly *how* he’d stopped two armed men and one meta.

“Anyway, Mr. Moss, may I ask what brings you back here today?” Mrs. Espinoza continued, still keeping a careful distance from him.

“It’s Monday, I wasn’t injured in the fight, and I didn’t get any e-mail about the office being closed,” Donald told her. He tilted his head slightly, trying to see what she was getting at.

“No, I understand that work is proceeding as normal today. I was just wondering why you felt the need to show up.”

“Because...” At last, comprehension dawned on Donald. “Wait, did I get *fired*?”

“Certainly not, Mr. Moss, certainly not,” Mrs. Espinoza protested, her voice rising a few octaves, as if she wanted others to be aware of the conversation that was taking place. “Vendallia Industries would never violate federal law by firing someone upon discovering they were a meta-

human, especially a meta-human who helped safeguard our office only days before. We just all assumed that, when the AHC scooped you up, you'd prefer working with them to your simple job here."

Donald glanced around, noticing that nearly everyone else in earshot had stopped what they were doing to watch the scene that was unfolding in his cubicle. He wasn't sure if they were hoping he would deck the boss or slink out the door, but it seemed pretty clear they'd been waiting all morning for exactly this discussion to take place. Much as he wanted to be annoyed or even angry, Donald reminded himself that only a month or so ago he'd have been staring with as much, if not more, curiosity. Metas were nothing if not fascinating.

"Nice as the AHC has been, I didn't feel right leaving my work unfinished," Donald said at last. "Besides, I like working here; the people are nice and pay is fair. Maybe once I get a little more settled in my new... side job... that will change, but for the moment, I'm happy to be here doing my part."

"And we're happy to have you." In spite of the forced smile on her face as Mrs. Espinoza fled his cubicle, he had a feeling that management was anything but happy to have him around. A meta was one thing, but a meta who'd openly come out as a cape and might be targeted for retribution, that was a whole other kettle of fish.

Staring at the code on his computer screen, Donald wondered if he was selfish for trying to come back here. This wasn't his world, not anymore. All he was really doing was disrupting the lives of people who had normal jobs to get done. Maybe it would be better if he just stayed at the AHC headquarters and spent this time training. There was obviously some sort of stipend available; pretty much zero famous capes held day jobs.

Donald started to push away from his desk, turning on reflex to tell Tori he was heading out, when he realized he'd be talking to an empty workstation. He paused, then pulled his chair back to its proper position. He couldn't leave, not just yet. The least Donald owed Tori was a proper goodbye, and an apology for leaving her out of the story. One week of

working amid the stares and whispers wasn't that high of a price to pay if it meant setting things right.

Plus, if Donald were completely honest with himself, he wasn't sure he'd ever see her again if he left without saying something. And he definitely didn't want to have seen the last of Tori Rivas.

\* \* \*

Balaam sat in the small media room, one occasionally used for classic film screenings or bad movie nights. It had a dozen leather chairs set up in a tiered seating system, a popcorn machine in the corner with a soda fountain adjacent, and a massive screen at the far end of the windowless room. Although he'd availed himself of the popcorn—that smell made it nearly impossible to resist—it wasn't a movie that Balaam sat watching in the darkness. At least, not a fictional one.

On the screen before him, Fornax leapt off the ground, so much magical energy pouring off him that the camera warped and stuttered, barely able to sustain its task. There were precious few records of this fight, or any of Fornax's battles for that matter. Of course, Balaam had pored through the accounts and testimonies from witnesses at the various scenes, but that was a poor substitute for watching the action himself. And was there ever action.

He watched as Fornax collided in midair with the glowing figure that was Lodestar. While his name was a silly reference to a black hole, hers was actually a well-chosen moniker. People often described the aura Lodestar put off as golden, but it only appeared that way in the after-streaks it left behind. When one gazed into the genuine article, they could see it was a silver-white color, like the twinkling of a star on a dark night. Except that she didn't twinkle: she burned like the heart of a demon.

In a single swing, Lodestar whipped Fornax around, smashing him into the concrete and sending the amateur cinematographer scrambling for cover. When they reemerged, she stood on top of Fornax, raining down blows that would have shattered mountains. Yet he took each one with that madman's grin he'd been so famous for. Seizing an opportunity, he kicked her in the stomach, barely moving her back an inch but giving himself time to move. In a blink, he was behind her, and the fight began anew.

Balaam had watched this and every other known video of Fornax's fights more times than he could actually count, just as he'd watched the ones of Doctor Mechaniacal, Xelas, and Morgana. Of the entire guild, they were the only four who might be strong enough to stop him, should a fight ever occur. Gork and Stasis, while powerful in their own right, were easily circumvented, at least.

As a spellcaster and a man who had embraced that title in every sense of the word, Balaam had long been a believer in preparation above all else. Even if the possibility of a fight with his fellow councilors didn't loom on the horizon, he preferred to be ready anyway. One never knew what others were scheming, after all. That was why he took time out of his schedule to watch these tapes. Hell, that was why he'd had Warren watch the video from the desert trial over and over again until his apprentice knew the capabilities of the others backwards and forwards. The more one knew, the more one could be ready for, and the higher the chances of victory in any given situation.

This all sounded good on paper, though if one were to check the logs of Balaam's viewing habits, they might notice that he watched the Fornax videos far more than any of the others. If pressed, he would have defended the choice by saying that, as one of the most dangerous metas on record, Fornax warranted the most research. Or, if the query came from someone who knew him well, he would simply say that he enjoyed watching Fornax get pummeled, which Lodestar certainly achieved. But while both of those answers had some merit, neither of them would be entirely true. Because the simple fact of the matter was that, much as he might loathe Ivan Gerhardt for tucking his tail between his legs and giving up on what had made him great, Balaam felt the same as he had when he first saw these fights as a child.

They were thrilling, filled with tension and excitement, the power of the two individuals involved palpable even through the camera. This moment in time, this battle between demi-gods, was what encapsulated metas more than anything else in their history. This was what they could be when truly pushed to be their best.

This was what they would be again, when Balaam was finished.

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## Chapter 41

After Friday's attack on the office, a full weekend of combat training at the guild, and spending all of Monday locked in the basement working on her meta-suit, coffee and willpower were the only things propping Tori up as she got dressed for their first night of field training. Ivan had sent her over to the guild headquarters early, and she'd found a simple black outfit waiting for her in her room. Unlike the apprentice costumes, this one wasn't meant to mark one as anything special. It was dark, certainly, but also purposefully mundane. Anyone who looked at Tori in it would think she was just another person on the street, maybe walking to a restaurant or bar. Had she just arrived at the guild, Tori would have found the choice strange. After learning from Ivan for so long, however, she understood the value of blending in.

The only part of the outfit that wasn't spectacularly normal was a silver pendant with a stone that had a rainbow of shifting colors set in the center. Obviously it was magic, which meant Tori instantly found herself somewhat distrustful of the curious accessory. There was no sense in fighting the inevitable, though—another lesson she'd picked up from Ivan—so she slipped it carefully over her head. A light tingle ran through her body as soon it fell against her chest, but after a few seconds of waiting, she didn't notice anything else. With a shrug of acceptance, Tori finished getting ready and headed out the door.

She was the last to arrive in the lounge area; Lance, Beverly, and Warren were dressed in similar, but not identical, clothing to hers, and each boasted a pendant of their own, all with the same odd moving colors swirling about in the stones. No sooner had she taken a few steps into the room than a familiar voice greeted her, although it was one she hadn't heard in quite a while.

"Good evening, everyone. For those of you who don't know me yet, my name is Arcanicus." He looked the same as he had the last time Tori laid eyes on him, same lightly-wrinkled visage and crisp purple robes. His eyes, however, were more alive than they had been back then; clearly, he was

more excited for this task than he'd been while conjuring skeletons for some upstart rookie to firebomb.

"Tonight, we begin your training outside this guild. Different nights will call for different tactics. Sometimes you will be shadowing guild members as they go on actual jobs. On other occasions, you'll be completing small tasks for me. These won't be anything ostentatious: merely exercises to get you past the first-time jitters and accustomed to working in the field."

Seeing as Tori had logged plenty of time out in the real world and had, in fact, gotten recruited by breaking into one of the guild's holding facilities, she wasn't feeling any of those jitters Arcanicus warned them about. All the same, it wasn't a bad strategy for rookies. Getting their feet wet in a relatively safe environment would give them the chance to get past any fears that might surface. Better then than in the middle of a real job when they could let people who needed them down.

"Since tonight is your first outing, we're going to take things slowly," Arcanicus continued. "We'll do a little walking around downtown, getting used to moving as a squad, and then swing by the diamond exchange where Pod Person is scheduled to do a quick break-in. If you have any questions during that event, please hold them until after we're back at the guild and they can be asked safely. Before we get to any of that, however, I should probably brief you on the equipment you've been issued."

No one needed prompting to look at the pendants hanging from their necks; they knew immediately what Arcanicus was referencing.

"Those are stones of obfuscation, handcrafted by yours truly. So long as you're wearing them, you'll be unmemorable to anyone who sees you. No one will be able to give an accurate description of what you looked like, people you know won't recognize you, even cameras will turn warped and blurry when you're in frame. The exceptions to this effect is others who are wearing the pendants—that's why you recognize each other—and the creator himself, of course. They are very expensive, so take care not to lose them or you will be billed and it will not be cheap. They'll be returned to me each night at the end of training and reissued the next day. For

reference, I also rent these out to guild members to use on actual jobs, so if you ever need one, just come see me to negotiate the price.”

Tori looked at the stone with new respect; the ability to hide them all from being noticed or remembered was pretty incredible. What’s more, it was something she didn’t think she could easily accomplish with science or technology. Much as her natural inclination went against it, she might have to learn a little more about the arcane arts. They were proving too useful to disregard.

“All right, everyone, follow me. I’ve got Tunnel Vision on standby, waiting to transport us across the city. Other nights we’ll take a car, but I thought it would be pleasant to begin on an easier foot.” Arcanicus headed out of the lounge and the apprentices followed, eager and nervous as they headed toward their first night loose in the real world amid villains of the guild.

\* \* \*

In spite of all the buildup, or perhaps because of it, their night started off rather boring. Arcanicus walked them around downtown, letting them get used to the way people’s eyes seemed to slide off them under the spell of the obfuscation stones. It was disconcerting initially, but once the strangeness wore off, they each began experimenting more with the limits of what the magical pendants could do. Lance tried to strike up a conversation with some women walking to a club and managed to hold their attention for all of half a minute before the sound of a honking horn distracted them and he fell out of their attention. Tori dropped an empty soda can on the ground in front of a cop, who frowned when he saw it then put it in the garbage. Warren slipped into a bar, ordered a drink, and then emerged without bothering to pay, the bouncer not even giving him a second glance.

Only Beverly kept her interactions normal, stopping someone to ask for the time, trying to bum a cigarette off a few guys gathered outside a club, and getting directions from the same cop who had thrown Tori’s can into the garbage. The difference was that Beverly did all three of these things on a loop, waiting first five minutes, then three, then one between each round. On the final occasion, one of the smoking men squinted at her

like she seemed familiar but still handed over a cigarette. Beverly rejoined the others, tossing the tobacco stick into the trash on top of Tori's discarded can.

"Looks like too much interaction either wears them down, or coming back too soon makes you recognizable," Beverly reported.

"Very good," Arcanicus said, nodding and shaking the purple robe. No one they met had commented on Arcanicus's strange attire, which didn't surprise any of the apprentices. A man who could make items like what they were wearing no doubt had a few tricks of his own in use. "The stones, like all magic, have limitations," he explained. "No power is infinite, and those with truly strong wills can sometimes pierce the illusions cast by such items. Beverly was smart to assess the limits of her new tool in a practical method that carried little risk. Whenever you're counting on new equipment, you need to know just how far it will take you."

Warren seemed annoyed while Lance and Tori gave Beverly small looks of respect. It was easy to forget how good a head she had on her shoulders when contrasted with the hulking forms she could assume. Arcanicus headed away from the bar area where they'd been hanging out for the last half-hour, and they followed his lead.

"Many years ago, before we implemented the current job approval system, we used to mark every building that was off-limits to guild members," Arcanicus told them. "This included buildings owned by guild holdings, places where family of members worked, and anywhere that a cape was suspected to have loved ones of their own. It worked well, for a time, but there are obvious flaws in any system like that."

Moving his hand up to the exterior brick wall of a mortgage company, Arcanicus muttered under his breath and tapped his finger to the cold surface. A softly glowing rune appeared on the bricks, hovering in place for several seconds before vanishing.

"There are plenty of magic-users among the AHC, and they eventually discovered the marks we'd left. Additionally, some of the other criminal metas found them too, which made for a far more dangerous situation. The system inadvertently told them all the places where useful holdings and hostages could be acquired. Eventually, we got around the

mistake by just marking every building in town, as well as putting down any of the groups who tried to attack them. These were a bloody few years, and when they ended, our guild had inadvertently become the underworld's overseer. We established ourselves as the collective king of the criminals, and ever since then, we've made sure to keep that spot by whatever means are necessary."

Arcanicus turned and looked at the apprentices, measuring the determination in their eyes. "But that will come later. As I said, tonight we start out slow. Pod Person's work will begin soon; let's head that way."

All five of them walked through the downtown Ridge City streets, seen but unremembered. It was an almost surreal experience for Tori, trekking from block to block, neighborhood to neighborhood, all under the light of stars and streetlamps. They passed upscale apartments and condos then made their way through a patch of the city known for being more dangerous. Capes and cops did have limits, and spots like this were where those breaks in the seams showed. No one bothered them as they walked calmly across the streets, though. That was probably for the best, as no low-level pusher with a gun would possibly be prepared to try and mug this group. It occurred to Tori that perhaps the pendants were as much for the protection of others as themselves. Guild members weren't exactly the sort that would hold back in a fight, so this kept the body count low, which made things easier on everyone involved.

They walked past a few more clusters of apartments before heading into another business district. While the first had held mostly bars and shops, this was clearly a place where money changed hands. Banks were all over the place, as were the logos of several Fortune 500 companies. Most telling of all, though, was how many buildings bore no labels beyond an address. They were the sorts of places that people only went to if they knew they had business there. Walk-ins need not bother.

Sitting on a bench in front of one of the banks, eating a salted pretzel nearly dripping with mustard, was a man Tori recognized from the guild's halls but couldn't have put a name to if her life was on the line. Given that he wore an identical pendant to theirs, however, it seemed like a logical bet that this was Pod Person, the guild member with the job going down that evening.

“Hey there, Apprentices.” He rose from his seat, gobbling down the last of the pretzel in a few hurried bites, then wiping his hands on the napkin and tossing it in the trash. “Arcanicus, you’re cutting it a little close on the time.”

“Foot travel is not exactly an easily predictable tactic,” the older man grumbled. They shook hands quickly, and Arcanicus sat down on the sidewalk, chalk suddenly appearing in his hand. He mumbled something under his breath as he began to draw lines on the concrete.

“While Arcanicus sets up the barrier for you all to watch behind, let me introduce myself. I go by Pod Person, and in exchange for free use of one of his fancy necklaces, I agreed to let you all observe my heist tonight. We only have a few minutes left before the others and I arrive, so let’s go through the ground rules for you four as spectators.”

Everyone shared a confused look at the words “the others and I arrive,” but all remembered Arcanicus’s warning about questions and so kept their silence. Besides, this seemed like a question that would answer itself if they were willing to be patient. It was a good thing they didn’t try to ask, because Pod Person didn’t slow down his speech, continuing right along without pause.

“The barrier Arcanicus is setting up will shield you from view so long as you stay behind it. There’s also a little bit of protective magic going in to the barrier, but if you’re in this guild, then I doubt you’ll need it. Here’s the most important thing you need to remember tonight: no matter what happens, you do not get to intervene. This is my job. I submitted it to the council, I got it approved, and I am the one who is allowed to work it. If things go bad, if I look like I’m in trouble, if you hear me screaming desperately for you to help, you still stay put. The *only* possible exception is if I’ve severely miscalculated and you end up in danger, at which point Arcanicus will give you permission to do something, probably run. Don’t expect it to come to that, though. There’s a reason this job was picked for you to watch, and part of it is because there’s very little chance of catastrophe.”

Behind Pod Person, Arcanicus rose from the ground, chalk still in hand. He made a wide, sweeping gesture over the runes he’d drawn. A

ripple appeared to run through the air in front of them. It stayed there, shimmering softly in the streetlights, giving the effect of looking down the road on a hot summer day.

“That’ll do it,” Arcanicus announced.

“About time, I’m going to be here any minute.” Pod Person reached into his jacket and yanked out a nondescript black ski mask. Pulling it over his head, his features disappeared under what appeared to be exceptionally scratchy wool. “Time to call for reinforcements.”

Every one of the apprentices jumped back slightly when Pod Person first spat on the ground, giving him a wide berth as he hocked up loogie after loogie. With each expectoration came a small green object, like an unripe bean, that landed on the sidewalk without so much as a bounce. The beans grew at an incredible rate before their eyes until, mere seconds later, they were the size of an adult human. That turned out to be appropriate, as one by one they split open, revealing perfect copies of Pod Person, lacking only the enchanted pendant.

“Boys,” Pod Person announced to his recently-hatched clones. “You know what to do. As for the rest of you, stay put and get ready for a show.”

## Chapter 42

Pod Person's... pod people had scarcely tucked themselves out of sight in a nearby alley when a car came speeding down the road. It pulled up in front of one of the many unlabeled buildings, and from its depths emerged four men wearing masks. The disguises were nothing fancy like what the guild would have issued; they looked like cheap balaclavas not much different from the ones Pod Person and his copies were already wearing.

"This is what we call a Trojan Horse job," the original Pod Person, identifiable by means of his pendant, explained. Unlike his duplicates, he'd stayed behind the barrier with Arcanicus and the others, evidently to provide color-commentary. It seemed imprudent to be speaking so freely with strangers only just across the street, but precautions must have been in place because not a single head turned in their direction. Instead, all four men were gathering up near the door of one of the buildings, the smallest of them typing away on some handheld computer.

"Basically, this crew has been pulling heists around town, and while they aren't technically doing anything to bring down the guild's full wrath, they did step on a few toes," Pod Person continued. "One of the men over there is me; he's been working for weeks to get in good with them as a safe-cracker. Tonight, once they've successfully robbed the diamond exchange, I'll use my knowledge of their plans to ambush them with all the other versions of me."

"We rarely do jobs in Ridge City," Arcanicus told them, not paying attention to the four men as they successfully opened the door and poured inside. "While the AHC has a presence all over the world, working in their backyard is unnecessarily risky. Generally, the only work we do around here is enforcement, which will be covered on another night. Pod Person is an infiltration specialist, however. Since he has the ability to bail out of a situation when the need arises, he gets cleared to do certain local jobs."



“I’m not big on travel.” Pod Person gave a hearty shrug, slightly rattling the pendant around his neck. “I’ve got another me for that. He’s in London at the moment, which I will say is a far more beautiful city than pictures really do justice capturing.”

Arcanicus and Pod Person spoke a bit more, going over the details of how Pod Person had wormed his way into the crew over the last few months. Things seemed to be going smoothly when suddenly a noise like a muted firecracker echoed through the air. Pod Person let out a long, annoyed sigh and turned in the direction of the building being robbed.

“Those two-timing rat bastards. They just shot me in the head. Can you believe that? Sure, I was going to rob them too, but I wasn’t planning to kill any of them. And what, for my part of the score? What if they need another safe-cracker? That’s just unprofessional, that’s what it is.”

Pod Person remained still, but from the nearby alley his clones poured forth, arranging themselves closer to the entrance while remaining largely hidden from view. One enterprising double skulked forward, sliding under the car and pulling out a large knife that gleamed in the streetlight.

“I guess it’s a good thing it happened, sort of. Lets me show the rookies how to adapt to changes,” Pod Person said. “See, I was going to use the me inside to know exactly when they were emerging so I could catch them perfectly by surprise and cut off their chance to run back inside. With that option gone, I’ll have to be fast instead of precise and ambush them the moment they pop out. Just to be on the safe side, I’m also cutting off their escape route. On a job, you can never count on things going to plan. That’s why it’s so important to always be... ready... to...”

His voice trailed off as he stared at the small, blinking red light coming from the watch on his left wrist. A quick glance at Arcanicus, who pulled back his robe to show a crystal pendant that was also blinking red, seemed to solidify Pod Person’s certainty regarding the situation.

“Well... tits. This just got a lot more complicated. Arcanicus, full evacuation, do you think?”

“I’m actually leaning away from that,” Arcanicus replied. “None of us are doing anything illegal; we’re all just out on a nightly stroll. It might

be a good opportunity for them to see the capes in action. Not to mention to observe how you handle such an unexpected development.”

“You’re a real bastard when you get the inclination, you know that?” Pod Person glanced over his shoulder, then up into the sky, before turning to face the apprentices once more. “Okay, rookies, what Arcanicus and I just got warning of is that superheroes from the Alliance of Heroic Champions have been dispatched to this scene. Guess the crew’s alarm specialist wasn’t as good as he thought he was. Anyway, in a situation like this, the very first recourse for a guild member is a simple one: bail. If at all possible, bail, run, and get clear of the situation. Which reminds me...”

Lifting his hand into the air, Pod Person snapped his fingers. The seemingly innocuous gesture was anything but given that each nearby copy of him exploded into a cloud of green goop. The muck splattered all over the ground, steam rising from its viridian depths. Before their eyes, the puddles grew smaller. They soon realized that the steam was more than just effect: the goop was rapidly evaporating.

“There we go: did the one inside too just for good measure, which is no doubt freaking out those double-dealing douchebags.” Pod Person reached up and pulled his mask off, handing it over to Arcanicus, who turned it to ash with a single bright flash of fire. “Ideally, Arcanicus’s spells will keep us off any of the capes’ radar, but with other metas, you can never take things for granted. However, as of now, none of us were involved in the burglary. We’re all just out walking the town, helping our wizard friend test his new enchanted items. That is still, admittedly, suspicious as hell, but without solid evidence, they won’t try to push it. The guild of villains has far better lawyers than they do. Like watches over like, as the saying goes.”

“I know we’re supposed to wait until we get back to ask questions, but seeing as things have gone off the rails, do you mind if I slip one in?” Lance said, stepping slightly forward.

“Is it about the watch?” Pod Person asked.

“It is definitely about the watch,” Lance confirmed.

“There’s nothing too special about it. The AHC tries to coordinate with police whenever possible—no need to double-book the same crime or

put human police in the middle of a meta-brawl. Doctor Mechanical wrote a program that monitors all the emergency channels and lets off a warning if the GPS chip in the watch senses we're near where the capes have been dispatched."

"There's also a magical relay system." Arcanicus pulled back his robe sleeve again so they could see the glowing crystal. "Since many of us who use the arcane arts have a tendency to short out electronics, it just sends the information from the computer version through a different method."

"It's a good tool to have, but you should never count on it," Pod Person added. "The AHC *likes* to coordinate with other agencies; that doesn't mean they always do so. Especially if they think we're involved and it might tip us off. Then they use discre—"

Pod Person was cut off by a thunderous blast filling the air. The car went up like there had been dynamite hidden inside, along with the remains of Pod Person's double still steaming beneath it. The combustion let out a blast of heat so intense they could feel it across the street. No one had to bother speculating on what had caused the explosion, as seconds later the familiar form of Blunderbuss came crashing to the ground, the end of his mighty weapon still smoking slightly. Squat, thick, and with the all-but-trademarked beard, Blunderbuss was impossible to mistake for anyone else, even without his giant gun. Above him swirled the familiar winds of Roto, who descended gracefully with another person gripped carefully in her flying vortex.

Although to say *person* might have been a bit of a stretch. The creature that landed on the concrete was a hybrid of dozens of animals, none of them exactly what one would call cuddly. Despite such a fierce appearance, the creature immediately swept the area upon landing with a quick, cunning intelligence. Its eyes, feline and golden, squinted slightly when they rested on Arcanicus's barrier, but eventually that gaze continued past them.

"That should put the fear of all nine hells into them," Blunderbuss declared, whipping his gun around and resting it on his shoulder. "Now, go charging in and take their weapons away. After that, you bundle them up

nice and tight for the police. Been tracking this crew for a while and none of them are meta, so it should be an easy fight. Just remember not to be too hard on them. Scratches and bruises can make for the wrong kind of sympathy.”

“Good luck, Medley,” Roto said, her voice so soft it was nearly impossible to hear from across the street. “We’re here if you need us, but you can handle this. It’s your debut, so take your time and do the best you can.”

The creature—Medley, presumably—nodded its shaggy head and moved toward the door. For a split second, its eyes veered off track and he looked at Arcanicus’s barrier again, but soon the sound of a gun cocking echoed, drawing its attention to the task at hand. With more grace than its form would have betrayed, Medley leapt inside, greeted immediately by the screams of the would-be diamond thieves.

“Lovely, lovely. Sounds like he’s handling them no problem,” Blunderbuss said. Gun shots filled the air, their tinny pops nothing like what he’d let loose yet still unmistakable. The sound halted suddenly a few seconds later. “Roto, is the press on their way?”

“The call was supposed to go out three minutes after we left, so based on current response times, it seems likely,” Roto replied. “Apollo *definitely said* we shouldn’t have Medley debut in the daytime, right? Having him work under cover of night... I feel like it’s going to do more harm than good.”

“Testing data shows people were far more weirded out by seeing Medley in sunshine than shadow. His presence at night, at least, meshes with what they expect of someone who looks like him.” Blunderbuss glanced at the flickering fire of the freshly exploded car. “Maybe we should move this a little out of the way, though. Might make him look menacing.”

“I told you not to shoot it,” Roto said as she created a new swirling vortex beneath what remained of the vehicle. The wreckage rose slowly but progressively until she shifted it several feet out of the way and placed it back on the ground.

“I didn’t want the damn crooks to scatter,” Blunderbuss defended. “Hunting them down would have thrown off the timetable. This got them all to hole up in one spot.”

“Maybe so, but you also flung debris and what looks like brake fluid all over the ground.” Roto leaned in closer, examining one of the small still-steaming puddles of goop. “I mean, it can’t be oil, that much is obvious, but I’ve never seen brake fluid this color, either. Car must have really been in need of a tune-up.”

“Wait a damn minute...” Blunderbuss hunkered down to his knees, carefully inspecting the remaining goop on the ground.

“And that, my dear rookies, is our cue to leave,” Pod Person announced. “Between the fact that cops and reporters are en route and ole Blundy preparing to put two and two together, we’re best getting while the getting is good.”

“I’ll keep a barrier woven over us until we’re out of sight,” Arcanicus said. “Doing one on the fly means I won’t be good for much else, but I should be able to manage for at least a block.” With that, he lowered his head, pressed his hands together, and began to mutter softly under his breath.

Pod Person took charge, guiding Arcanicus by the shoulders and motioning for the apprentices to follow along. Together they walked as quietly as they could away from the scene, not pausing or stopping until they were several blocks away from the action, at which point Arcanicus let his spell end. They proceeded to head back to downtown, protected now only by the pendants around their necks. It seemed things had gone their way, in the end. A good demonstration of dealing with capes, a little knowledge of how to work in the field, and no one had gotten seen or noticed. They’d made it through their first night without any apparent negative effects whatsoever.

\* \* \*

Apollo watched as the group walked through the streets, his golden glowing eyes easily piercing the pathetic spells of a tired mage like Arcanicus. He stood perched atop a nearby building, careful to stay unseen

by both the villains and his fellow capes. Medley was a powerful meta with ample potential and while he wanted to make sure the debut went just as they'd planned, Apollo couldn't have the others know he was checking up on them. That would be bad for morale and worse for trust.

"Going to stop them?" Lady Shade stood near him, her cloak of endless shadows concealing his constant glow. It wasn't often that Apollo needed to do things covertly, but when the occasion arose, she was the one he trusted to make it happen. It certainly didn't hurt that her powers made getting around much easier and that she trusted him enough to not question his orders.

"Certainly not," Apollo said, grabbing his chest as if wounded. "For one thing, we've got no proof they had anything to do with tonight's robbery; that is to say, we've got nothing a capable lawyer couldn't turn into reasonable doubt, anyway. Besides, the last thing I want to do is split the media's focus. Tonight is about Medley and his spectacular debut, not about us bringing in bystanders with magical equipment for questioning. He caught his criminals red-handed; the whole thing tied up so nicely I may as well have put a bow on it for him. More arrests complicate things, and the debut needs to be simple."

"If you say so, but you sure were watching them closely for someone you don't want to bust." Lady Shade glanced over the edge of the building. Unlike Apollo, she could only make out six distinct shapes amid the crew of escaping villains. Details were lost to her; even their relative size and shape were hard to pin down. Despite both having powers that were magical in origin, it was clear she and Apollo resided in entirely different leagues.

"Perhaps you can't tell, but of the six down there, four are people I've never seen before." That wasn't entirely true, actually. One of them, the woman with the long brown hair, did seem familiar, but Apollo couldn't figure out where he might know her from. He knew she'd never been hauled in for villainy, though; that would have stuck in his mind. "I'm committing their faces to memory, making sure I'll be properly prepared for when they don their masks and come mucking about in our nice, orderly world."

“Newbies, huh? Guess that confluence gave their guild a few fresh recruits as well.” Lady Shade squinted, the pale skin around her mousy eyes bunching up as she tried to make out more details in the vague shapes below. “But doesn’t it make more sense to try and pop them now before they’re skilled enough to actually be a problem? You could at least zip down and put a healthy dose of fear into them.”

Apollo reached out and put an arm around Lady Shade, the sort of friendly gesture she’d long ago learned was meant to be reassuring, not romantic. So far as she knew, Apollo didn’t have time for romance in his life. All he saw was the AHC and his place in it.

“That, my friend, would be doing a disservice to our own new recruits. Do you know what superheroes need, above all else? What gives us purpose, reminds the people that we matter, ensures that we will always have a place in this world?”

“Villains,” Lady Shade replied. “We have to have criminals and metas to fight, otherwise why would we be needed?”

“Precisely,” Apollo said. “They are evil, certainly, but a necessary evil. And when our new group of heroic champions is ready to go into the world, they will need villains to fight. The older, more experienced members of that guild are too wily and too dangerous to be their prey, but the new ones... now, they’re the sort that might just make some mistakes. I don’t want to stop them tonight; there’s no point in picking a fruit before it’s ripe. Better to wait until there’s a need to take them.”

He watched the group move through his street, golden eyes gleaming in spite of Lady Shade’s efforts to dim them.

“Even villains can have their uses, from time to time.”

## Chapter 43

By the time Friday morning rolled around, Tori was equal parts grateful to Ivan for getting her the week off and mutinous at the thought of having to deal with work and training when the next week started.

Thus far, the week had gone well, or at least less chaotically than their first night out. Tuesday, Arcanicus had sent them off into town with a list of various items they had to retrieve, the only condition being that they turned over their wallets first. Some had turned to shoplifting to complete the list; others used charm to get their way. For her part, Tori simply found a shipping warehouse that had everything she needed, snuck in as living fire, then made her way out under the cover of darkness.

Wednesday was another tagalong event, this time in Greenland, where they watched a bank get expertly robbed. Double Down and Slipshod were masterful to watch. They even slipped in counterfeit money in place of what they took, long delaying anyone's realization that a theft had even occurred. It was strange to see the scale the guild worked on, from low-level capers like the one Pod Person had planned to elaborate international heists that brought in millions of dollars. It really was a place where everyone worked at their own comfort level so long as they stuck to the code.

Thursday had left her the most drained since it entailed a whole evening walking into various locations to try and spot undercover cops, or worse, capes. The endless rotations of clubs, bars, and street corners coupled with the fact that she'd tied with Warren for fewest undercover officers noticed meant Tori had to drag herself through most of Friday's work on her meta-suit.

Much as she might have wanted to take a break, she knew there wouldn't be any chance to work on it through the weekend since Ivan's kids would be coming over again. That meant more combat training at the guild, which barely gave her enough free time to eat, let alone solder delicate circuitry in place. Things were going well, though; she had her fingers



crossed that by this time next week, she might just have a functioning prototype. There would be improvements to make, there always were, but for the moment, she just wanted something that worked. Whatever job they decided to pull off, Tori would feel a lot better going into it with a full suit of tech strapped to her body.

It was past one in the afternoon when she finally emerged from the basement, bleary-eyed and with a crick in her back from so many hours spent bent over the table. To her surprise, there was a plate of sandwiches sitting out, carefully covered with saran wrap. Ivan generally held to the belief that she could eat during mealtimes or prepare food herself, which made the gesture nice but suspicious.

“You look like hell.” His voice caught her by surprise, and she spun to find him sitting in a recliner, a thick book open in his hands. He cocked an eyebrow at her reaction, and Tori fought down the urge to blush.

“Yeah, you look like... I don’t know... an old guy who isn’t old enough for as old as he... fuck, I’ve got nothing.” She went to the fridge and reached for a beer, then thought better of it and grabbed a soda. There was still a lot of daylight to get through, not to mention night training once the sun set. She was better served by a caffeine boost than by alcohol, even if it was in small amounts.

“I think you should take a nap after lunch,” Ivan said once she returned to the kitchen table. Tori fumbled with the saran wrap, needing three tries to get to her sandwiches.

She took a large bite of the nearest sandwich she could grab. “It’d be nice,” she agreed. “But I’ve got too much work to do. I’ll fuel up on coffee and energy drinks before we train tonight, don’t worry.”

“Perhaps you misunderstand. I was not saying that as Ivan your caretaker. I was saying it as Pseudonym, your teacher.”

Tori swallowed her bite of sandwich hard, feeling it move through her throat like a small brick. Ivan didn’t play the apprentice card too often; he liked to let her make her own mistakes as she learned. If he was throwing it down now, it meant things were either about to get very serious or he was sincerely worried about her safety.

“Do I need the sleep that bad?”

“You’ll be far better served if you have your wits about you this evening,” Ivan replied, turning his attention back to his book. “And caffeine is a poor substitute for genuine awareness. Spend your afternoon as you wish, this is just my opinion on the matter.”

Both of them knew his opinion was usually more than just that, at least when he cared enough to share it. Tori wolfed down the rest of her lunch, the hunger she’d been ignoring all morning finally making itself known, and guzzled down her soda. Once that was done, she considered heading back to the lab for a few more minutes, just to finish up what she’d been working on. But before the idea could take root, Tori recognized it for the slippery slope it was. As soon as she went in there, time would lose all meaning, and before she knew it, the hour to head off to the guild would have arrived. Granted, that had been her plan until a few minutes ago, but she decided to heed Ivan’s advice instead.

Heading up to her garage apartment, Tori squeezed in a quick shower, dressed in some comfortable pajamas, and laid down in her bed. She had a book in hand, anticipating needing a little winding down time before her brain would allow her the sweet release of slumber. This proved to be unnecessary. No more than a minute after her head hit the pillow, Tori Rivas was fast asleep and softly snoring.

Hours later, when a knock on the door from Ivan startled her awake, she would swear she had just closed her eyes seconds prior, which only went to show how right he’d been about her need for sleep. Especially with the long night she had ahead of her.

\* \* \*

“I seriously hate you for dragging me into this,” Johnny said, hefting a case of mid-range beer higher in his arms. It was clearly weighing him down, which was all the more embarrassing when contrasted with the fact that Thuggernaut was carrying an entire poker table over his head. Even Arachno Bro was easily carting around a dozen shopping bags on his long, furry arms.

“Hate all you want, just don’t jostle the beer,” Thuggernaut ordered. He kept walking at the same pace, refusing to let Johnny’s whining slow them down. “And don’t sneak any either, they’re for tonight.”

“Which I maintain is something the male members of the council should be doing, since all the women are the ones putting together the girls’ night.” Johnny adjusted his grip on the beer once more, trying to keep the cardboard from cutting into his palms. While the villain known as Johnny Three Dicks had plenty of talents, enhanced strength wasn’t one of them, nor were invulnerable palms.

“Great idea,” Arachno Bro said, his words coming out slightly slurred due to the mandibles protruding from his mouth. “We’ll just get Pseudonym, who only comes for required guild matters, Balaam, who’s even an asshole to his own apprentice, and Doctor Mechaniacal, the man burdened with running a Fortune 500 Company and a guild of criminals, to spend their Friday night hanging out with a pair of apprentices.”

“I never said it would be easy,” Johnny mumbled halfheartedly.

“Doctor Mechaniacal was nice enough to give us access to one of the fancier lounges and let us expense all the refreshments,” Thuggernaut reminded them. “If we want to welcome the guys in, it’s up to us to put in the actual work.”

“I think Pod Person and Arcanicus might stop by too.” Arachno Bro stepped carefully to the side as Thuggernaut navigated through a doorway with his table, then let Johnny putter past. “Said they wanted to see the rookies off the clock.”

“Or they heard we’d have free booze,” Johnny pointed out, “which is how you baited me into this, so I suppose I can’t give them too much grief. Though I should point out that they aren’t here helping us haul the supplies.”

“No, they actually helped out with the training,” Thuggernaut said. They arrived outside of a wide metal door none of them had been through before. Reaching over, Thuggernaut pressed his thumb to a digital pad adjacent to the handle. A small beep could be heard and the door swung

open. Carefully maneuvering his table, Thuggernaut walked up the red-carpeted stairs into a sweeping room.

“Damn.” Johnny let out a soft whistle as he surveyed their surroundings. “This almost makes me want to earn enough to make it to the Executive level. I didn’t even know we had spots like this.” The room was covered in the same lush red carpet that swathed the stairs. Several recliners and a large couch were scattered around, far nicer than the ones in the general lounges. A bar staffed by a pair of robotic butlers occupied the far corner of the room. Televisions were dotted about, as were tablets for those who wanted to surf the web while hanging out.

“This is nothing,” Arachno Bro told him. “Once I robbed a gold reserve and actually made it to the guild’s top ten percent of earners. You should see the Executive break rooms. More robots, free everything. It’s nuts. I spent so much time enjoying the facilities that I forgot to pull any jobs, and after a month it was back to the common quarters.”

Thuggernaut set the table down in a clear spot near the center of the room. He was only guessing, but he suspected that Doctor Mechaniacal had specifically altered the room’s layout just for their use; otherwise, the arrangement of furniture didn’t make much sense. “I think it’s smart of Doctor Mechaniacal to let us use this space. Good chance to show the kids what they can get, if they put in the work.”

“Ugh, that word.” Johnny shivered, shaking his shoulders so hard that the lapels of his suit began to flap. “If I wanted to *work* I’d have stuck to a normal life, thank you very much. I prefer to do things that are fun, especially if they result in me taking home a significant amount of someone else’s money.”

“Right, so Johnny doesn’t get to talk tonight,” Arachno Bro suggested.

“I’ve known him for over a decade; if you can find a way to shut him up, I’ll pay you half my earnings for the next six months,” Thuggernaut offered.

Johnny’s ears perked up visibly. “If that deal goes to anyone in the room, I think we might be able to make an arrangement.”

“Not happening, you’d just find some loophole to weasel through.” Thuggernaut adjusted the table once then grabbed a few of the recliners and began setting them up around it. As he worked, Arachno Bro and Johnny took their supplies to the bar, where the robots immediately began putting things away. By the time they finished watching the MMA fight at the Ridge City Arena and Civics Center, everything would be properly chilled or heated as serving demanded. They’d come back to play cards with a big meal waiting for them.

If pushed, Thuggernaut might have admitted the festivities were a little trite for his sensibilities—he much preferred the opera to physical combat, seeing as he got enough of that in his line of work. Dealing with two young men, however, meant playing the odds and picking things that were most likely to be at least a little fun to all involved. Violence and drinking were solid bets for their age group, especially when one factored in that they were the type of people to join a guild of villains. Regardless, the point of the evening wasn’t the activities themselves; it was the bonding that would occur during them. Now that the rookies were this far along, it would be beneficial to give them some roots and connections beyond just their teachers. The more people they knew, the better off they’d be if they made it to full membership.

Thuggernaut tried not to think about that “if” as he continued to set things up. The best he could do was prepare his own apprentice and hope that when the time came, she proved herself worthy. Plus, if he started worrying now, he’d inevitably let his mind begin to ponder exactly what Xelas had in store for the women. And if he started down that path, he’d be a useless bundle of nerves all night long.

\* \* \*

“There’s my guy!” Apollo walked into the gym, breezing past the half-dozen other rookies who were giving Ren a wide berth as he used the bench press. Donald was standing over him, technically a spotter though they both knew anything Ren couldn’t lift was well beyond his league. While Donald wasn’t really the gym type, Ren was constantly exercising, and since he was the only friend Donald had made in the AHC, he’d decided to try and share the interest. It helped that a week of working in an

office full of people that were wary of him had left Donald with the uncharacteristic desire to burn off some frustration.

“Medley, my boy, your test scores have been coming back and they are just great,” Apollo announced. With one hand, he grabbed the bar laden with weights, lifted them easily from Ren’s clawed hands, and set it down back on the rack. Several noticed this feat of strength but few were surprised by it. Apollo wasn’t one of the world’s most famous superheroes for nothing.

“They are?” Ren sat up carefully, a bit dubious of such claims. He’d been warned over and over again that his looks might hinder the public’s response to him, which was why his image needed to be so carefully managed.

“They are! You’re testing about where we expected with adults—most find you scary, but since you’re on the side of the good guys, they’re okay with it. But guess what? Kids, the most marketable and impressionable demographic out there, they freaking love you. Think you look like a creature from some animated movie or such nonsense. Point is, you are scoring way above what we predicted with them.” Apollo lifted his hand high overhead, and after a moment’s pause, Ren took the cue and gave him a high-five. At least with Apollo, he didn’t have to worry about accidentally breaking his bones or stabbing him with his claws.

“That’s great,” Donald said, patting his friend on the furry/scaly shoulder.

“It sure is, and in celebration, I come bearing a gift,” Apollo said. From behind his back, he produced a silver bracelet no less than five inches wide with runes and inscriptions etched all over the metal surface. “Truth is, we’d ordered this for you a while back, but it happened to be ready today, so I’m going to call it a congratulatory present.”

“Um, thank you.” Ren accepted the odd piece of silver—more gauntlet than bracelet, if he were being honest. It was certainly interesting looking, though Ren wasn’t sure it went well with the primal image he had.

Apollo, clearly noting Ren’s confusion, only smiled wider. “Try it on, Medley. I promise, you won’t be disappointed.”

Ren carefully fitted the bracelet over his thick forearm, surprised by how much give it had. No sooner had it slipped across his flesh than the bottom part clicked, the two sections interlocking to form a complete circle around his wrist. The gasp from Donald was the first clue that something had changed, and as Ren examined the flesh around his wrist, he realized what it was. There was *flesh* around his wrist: pink, human, normal-looking flesh. Tentatively, he reached out, running a finger along the skin. It felt real... sort of. If he pushed too hard, he could sense the fur and scales that were really there, but that was only if he really tried.

“It’s just an illusion,” Apollo cautioned, watching as Ren rose from the bench to examine himself in one of the gym’s many mirrors. “As you know, we can’t give you back a true human-form. But with this, you can go back out into the world. Hit a bar, eat at a restaurant, do anything you want.”

Ren stared at the face looking back at him. It wasn’t his own—the size of his new body would have made that impossible. Instead, he looked like a competitive bodybuilder, all wide shoulders and a thick, nearly nonexistent neck. No, this face wasn’t his, but it *was* human. A tear slid down the pink skin of his normal face as Ren turned around to face Apollo.

“Thank you. Thank you so much.” Even his voice sounded different, less animalistic. For the first time since the night of the storm, Ren felt a flicker of hope in his stomach. A normal life was gone, that much was true, but now... now he wasn’t quite as trapped as he had been. Now there were possibilities other than being a monster.

“Hey, you earned it,” Apollo said. “And if you’re going to do this job, you need to be able to go out and let off a little steam here and there. In fact, I order you to do exactly that tonight. You too, Cyber Geek. Go out and take the bracelet for a test drive. Try a bar or a club or something fun. We already had some clothes brought to your rooms, so you can pick a stylish outfit to go with the new look.”

Donald wasn’t really one for going out to loud, social places, but one glance at Ren told him that refusal wasn’t on the table. Somehow the illusion was conveying his expression on the false face, and Ren was so overwhelmed with excitement by the idea that Donald was shocked he

hadn't sprinted out of the gym already. Whether it was his kind of scene or not was irrelevant; Ren was his friend, and this night would do him a world of good. Plus, it would mean ending the workout early, which Donald most certainly *was* in favor of.

“Let's hit the showers,” Donald said. “After that, you can come to my room and we'll make a game plan.”

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## Chapter 44

“Tonight, we are your instructors,” Xelas intoned.

No sooner had Tori arrived at the guild than she’d been hustled upstairs, into a large room she’d never seen before, filled with every female member of the council as well as Beverly. Lance and Warren were nowhere to be seen. Whatever was on the docket, she found herself grateful Ivan had urged her to take the nap. This was clearly more than just another night of training.

“We have planned an itinerary, secured transportation, and provided you with the necessary equipment. You are to go into the changing rooms we’ve set up and get ready for the night’s activities, which will only be revealed to you once we are en route.” Xelas pointed to a pair of curtained-off areas, no doubt only set up hours before, given their level of construction. “Beverly, you are in stall number one. Tori, you’re in stall number two. The rest of us will wait out here until you’re ready.”

Behind Xelas stood the other three councilwomen, expressions unreadable. Morgana and Stasis weren’t adorned in their usual costumes, Tori noted. Instead, they had sweeping cloaks that covered them from head to toe, even their faces obscured by the hoods drawn high overhead. Gork looked as she usually did, which was to say giant and gray, though there was a gleaming headband just above her eyebrows that Tori didn’t recall seeing before. No one was talking, so it seemed the only way to learn what was going on was to follow orders until they let her in on the secret.

Tori and Beverly made their way to the makeshift changing rooms. Pulling back the curtain, Tori found herself staring at a wide space with a small rack of clothing, a mirror, and a wide chair. All of that aligned with what she’d been expecting, but as she checked the outfit waiting for her, Tori got her first surprise of the night. It was not a new costume or some sort of camouflage. Instead, it was a black and red ensemble that would look more at home on a model than a villain.

“Um, Xelas,” Beverly said, sounding uncharacteristically uncertain. “Why are we dressing like this?”

“Sorry, Apprentice, but we’re not taking questions right now,” Xelas yelled back. “All you need to know is that tonight, you’ll learn how to blend in without the use of magical pendants.”

That explained more than Tori had hoped for; Arcanicus had told them he rented out his obfuscation pendants, so using them all the time was bound to be expensive. Learning to blend in, despite being out of their element, was a skill that was bound to come up more and more as they took on new jobs. With a grunt of determination, Tori shed her apprentice costume and slipped into the outfit they’d assigned her.

It fit well—perfectly, in fact—which was a bit worrying until Tori remembered they’d taken her measurements for her costume. She wore black pants, a red blouse, a cropped black jacket that slipped over her shoulders, and a pair of red heels she nearly tumbled out of after the first few steps. Tori had worn heels before, it just hadn’t been for quite a while. By the time she’d slipped on the last of her accessories, she’d reacquired the knack and emerged from the changing room with steady steps.

Beverly had finished first and was clad in a green dress that matched her eyes and wrapped around her in a way that left most, but not quite all, up to the viewer’s imagination. What was most striking about Beverly had nothing to do with the outfit, however. That honor went to the fact that she was staring, mouth slightly agape, over at the council members. Tori followed her friend’s gaze only to sport her own dumbfounded look seconds later.

The apprentices, it seemed, were not the only ones who had been changing. Morgana and Stasis had both shed their cloaks, revealing the stylish outfits beneath them. They’d styled their hair and done more elaborate makeup as well, making them almost unrecognizable as the two council members Tori had met before. More shocking even than them, however, were Xelas and Gork. Gork still towered over the rest of the group, though by far less of a margin, but now she did so looking like a model. Long, pale-blond hair and a creamy skin tone made her appear as though she hailed from Norway or Sweden or one of those countries Tori

knew housed women who were lovely, tall, and blonde. As for Xelas, there wasn't a trace of metal to be seen; she now looked like a tan woman with dark, short-cropped hair. It was really only the mischievous grin that gave away her identity, and even with that, Tori wasn't sure she'd have recognized Xelas if not for process of elimination.

"As I said, tonight is about blending in, something we all need to do from time to time," Xelas told them. Her voice, at least, was still the same. "Some of us do it with heels and makeup, while others use advanced holographic technology complete with bio-feedback. Point is, you never know when you have to be able to go down and mingle with the masses. And, after you both do your makeup, you'll both be ready to join us."

Morgana plucked a pair of small pouches from the ground and walked over, handing one to each of the apprentices. "Don't worry," she whispered while standing between them. "Xelas just likes putting on a show. Tonight will be a fun one."

"Ahem, if my cohort would stop undermining my attempts at fear-mongering, I'd greatly appreciate it," Xelas said. "Now then, if you'll both go to the bathroom and get your war paint on, we can head into the urban jungle that is Ridge City."

With little else to do in the way of options, Tori and Beverly complied and headed toward the restroom. As she walked, pouch of makeup in hand, Tori wondered what on earth Lance and Warren were going through. If they were stuck with the male council members, she didn't envy them in the slightest. Much as she respected Ivan, he wasn't exactly a barrel of fun. And whatever else one could say about the female councilors, the prospect of a night out with them was far from boring.

Dangerous and chaotic, almost certainly; just not boring.

\* \* \*

Though Tori didn't know it, at that moment the male apprentices had finished changing into suits and were heading to the garage with Thuggernaut, Johnny, and Arachno Bro. Like Xelas and Gork, Arachno Bro was employing camouflage to conceal his true appearance, while Johnny and Thuggernaut just used nice outfits. Thuggernaut was still obviously a

meta-human, as not many normal people were ten feet tall and essentially carved from muscle. Since he didn't have to worry about being recognized, Thuggernaut didn't bother hiding what he was, though he did make sure to buy the seats behind him at any given sporting event he went to so as not to obstruct anyone's view. While this might have been viewed as an act of kindness, it was also one of self-protection. People who got blocked sometimes decided to be confrontational, and Thuggernaut preferred to keep a low profile, something that was hard to do when forced to beat people senseless.

Unlike Tori and Beverly, the men hadn't been given even the slightest of hints at where they were going. All they were told was to change, not ask questions, and be ready for anything. Lance was convinced they were about to go rob a casino, while Warren worried they were being marched to attend a guild member's funeral. Luckily, they wouldn't be in the dark for much longer, as it was a short trip to their first destination where all would be made clear. While Warren would be greatly relieved by the truth, Lance would find himself just the slightest bit disappointed. He'd been pretty set on the casino robbery idea.

That would come later, though. At the moment, they merely marched down the stairs, flanked by their senior guild members who were working as hard as they could not to smirk and giggle. It was supposed to be a serious time, at least until they got to the fight, but the silliness and fun of what they were doing kept worming through their minds. They fought to suppress the smiles that wanted to bloom on their faces, but in their attempts to look stoic all three men appeared to be suffering from stomach issues, which only confused Lance and Warren all the more.

So it was that five men, three looking like they were fighting the urge to sprint for a toilet and two looking extremely confused, entered the garage only about ten minutes before their female counterparts. They made it into the SUV five minutes before Tori and Beverly's transportation arrived, which turned out to be a piece of very fortunate timing. Luxurious and practical though the SUV was, the guys would have been stricken by envy at the sight of what waited to bring the others out on the town.

\* \* \*

When Tori laid eyes on the limo, her first thought was that it would probably cost more than her yearly pay at Vendallia just to fill up its gas tank. Her second was to wonder why on earth they needed not only a limo, but one that looked like it had been cross-bred with a Humvee. That question, at least, was quickly answered as Gork ducked her head as she squeezed through the back door. Tori had allowed herself to forget that, holograms aside, this vehicle was still carting around a woman who was made entirely out of metal as well as one who Tori suspected to be at least thirty percent rock. That sort of weight was bound to wear down the shocks on a regular vehicle. Plus, this afforded them all enough room to travel in comfort. While appearing ostentatious, it was in fact a purely pragmatic way to get about town.

Had she floated this theory by Xelas, the robot woman would have blinked a few times, then completely agreed with her that of course that was why this limo had been chosen. She would have done so in spite of the truth that Xelas merely liked it. Tori did not offer up her theory, however, so she didn't get the chance to have it disproven through a lazy, halfhearted lie.

Once everyone was boarded, Morgana pulled out one of the many champagne bottles from the large cooler in the bar area of the limo, popping the cork with an expert flair and not letting so much as a single bubble spill onto the carpeted floor.

"Tonight, we are heading out on the town," Morgana said, filling the first champagne flute and passing it off to Stasis, who kept handing it along. "And as such, we will be pretending to be civilians. That means from this point on, we are no longer to refer to each other by our guild names. As of this moment, you can call me Lynn. Stasis will be Stacey, Gork is Gretchen, and Xelas is Alexis. You two already know each other's names, obviously."

She continued to pour, filling flute after flute until the only empty hand in the limo, robotic driver notwithstanding, was her own. Morgana—Lynn, for the evening—carefully filled her glass, set the bottle back in the cooler, and lifted her own flute.

"Now that we're officially out on the town, it's my pleasure to tell you that this evening's training is in networking. Specifically, getting to know your superiors in the guild and having a little fun while you're at it.

We do have quite a night planned, though none of it involves crime. At least, not until Xelas—pardon me, Alexis—gets a wild hair up her ass to cause mischief. But we’re going start things off with a toast to you two, the apprentices who’ve made it this far. While neither of you might have chosen this path if given the choice, we’re glad you did. Both of you have the potential to be fine members of this guild, and when the time for your last trial arrives, know that we’ll be rooting for you from the sidelines. Cheers.”

Lynn tossed back her glass of champagne, and moments later, so did everyone else. Gretchen was the only one not to finish hers, merely taking a respectful sip before setting down the glass. It rested in the mobile cup holder for no more than a few seconds before Alexis snatched it up and guzzled down the bubbly liquid.

“So, I have a question,” Beverly said, choosing her words carefully. “But I’m not sure if it’s offensive to ask or not. The last thing I want to do is start this night off by making a social error.”

“Oooh, she’d do well if she ran for the council,” Stacey commented.

“Your sentiment is noted,” Lynn replied, ignoring Stacey. “Go ahead and ask. We’ll tell you if it’s out of line.”

“Okay. I was just wondering, Xel—I mean, Alexis, how do you eat and drink stuff? Wouldn’t it mess up your circuitry?” Beverly asked.

Alexis killed the last of Gretchen’s champagne and set down the glass with a smile. “That’s probably a borderline question in general, but since it’s me, you’re fine. Without getting too bogged down in the science of it, I have a system that turns the food and liquid I drink into energy, just like with humans. It’s part of what helps power me, though it’s easily the least efficient method in use... one of the holdovers from my days as a *fuck-toy*. It’s actually the same reason I came pre-equipped with a holographic generator. Tech Lord liked to be able to take me out without people realizing he’d built his own girlfriend.”

Her usual half-mad cheer seemed to dissipate a bit toward the end of the explanation, a venomous thread of hatred worming its way through Alexis’s words.

Beverly's eyes got so round Tori could see the lines where her eyeshadow ended. While Tori had recognized Xelas from the moment they met, Beverly wasn't a technology-obsessed science geek who would know about the first artificial intelligence to sue for its freedom. Before Beverly could blurt out something that might be taken the wrong way, Tori set a hand on her fellow apprentice's arm.

"Did you know all artificially-created intelligence of a certain level has the right to emancipate itself from its creator? It's called Xelas's Law, named after the courageous mechanical woman who sued to be free from the cape who crafted her," Tori explained.

"Had a feeling you'd know about that," Alexis said. The dark tone seemed to vanish from her voice, replaced by more of the happy noise that Tori was only now beginning to suspect covered much deeper scars. "Most of the original me has been changed out over the years, but I like food, so I kept the stomach. Added some taste buds though so now I can actually appreciate what I'm eating. Speaking of which, how far out are we from the restaurant?"

"Only another five minutes or so," Stacey told her.

"Five minutes? Sweet Jesus, someone hand me that bottle of champagne. I'm not going to survive if I have to wait an entire five minutes." Without waiting for anyone to actually comply with her request, Alexis reached over, grabbed the neck of the open bottle, and gleefully sipped down the remainder of the sparkling wine.

"Nice to know this won't be different than any of our other girls' night outs," Stacey chuckled under her breath. Tori and Beverly exchanged worried glances, which only went to show that the weeks spent training with the guild had succeeded in heightening their ability to sense impending trouble.

## Chapter 45

Not for the first time that evening, Donald adjusted his tie. While he'd been perfectly content to go with Ren wearing a t-shirt and jeans, Barney and Jessica had been waiting for him the minute he approached his room. As a new member of the AHC, he had a certain image to project, which meant not going out to high-end clubs looking slovenly. And the clubs they were going to *would* be high-end, as would the restaurant where they grabbed dinner. While the AHC wouldn't go so far as to alert the press that one of the town's newest superheroes would be out and about, they certainly weren't going to risk people snapping pictures of him in jeans at a burger joint.

So they'd dressed him, made reservations at a restaurant Donald couldn't imagine being able to afford, and booked a roped-off VIP area in a newly opened club (all on the AHC's dime, thankfully) before car service picked him and Ren up. Unlike Donald's own expression, his friend's false face was brimming with excitement, his squat neck swiveling as he looked out the windows at the lights of downtown Ridge City. It occurred to Donald for the first time that, aside from busting the would-be diamond thieves, Ren probably hadn't left headquarters since the day he was transformed. Moments later, another thought struck him, and Donald's eyes went wide as a curse escaped his mouth.

"Oh, shit."

"What?" In an instant, the joy was gone from Ren's face. In its place was a primal, fierce gaze. He was ready for whatever threat might have interrupted their night and intended to make anyone responsible for ruining his first evening of freedom pay dearly.

"I just realized, I'm known outside my mask, but your face is brand new. If we go out like this, you'll be linked to hanging out with a cape and your anonymity goes out the window."

"Is that all?" Ren eased back into his seat, the tension melting away as an easy smile took its place. "Don't worry. Apollo already briefed me on



that and taught me how to deal with it. Turns out the doodad they gave me is more than a one-trick pony.”

Ren held up his wrist, where a projection of a fashionable watch concealed the magical bracelet. Touching it gently with his left hand (it looked to Donald as if he were simply adjusting the dial), Ren’s face and skin tone began to shift. In seconds, he no longer resembled the man Donald had gotten into the car with. With another quick spin, the image shifted once more, going back to the original setting.

“Multi-functional, in case I ever need to have different cover identities,” Ren explained. “They went all out on it. So don’t worry; even if people see this version of me tonight, I can always look like someone else if I want to go unnoticed later. But I don’t mind having an identity that’s associated with the AHC. If I’m doing the work, it might be nice to get a little recognition from time to time.”

“Doesn’t seem like there’s much chance of that not happening.” Donald peered out the window, noting all the people on the streets making their way to various places of entertainment. His usual social anxiety had his stomach churning, a sensation made all the worse by the fear that people might recognize him. The weight on his own wrist, a compact device tucked away beneath his sleeves and pre-programmed with a myriad of digital items to draw at his fingertips, seemed much heavier than it should.

Given the choice, Donald would have left without it, but on that point, there had been zero wiggle room. Every member of the AHC was expected to have whatever tools were needed for their power on them at all times. One never knew when trouble would break out or they’d be called into the field. For better or worse, he was a superhero now, and that meant there was no true time off. If the need arose, he was expected to act.

Donald tried not to think about that as they rolled down the streets. It was a Friday evening in a town that most of the nation’s superheroes called home. Things would be fine. He and Ren would have a fun night out, that was all.

He hoped.

\* \* \*

Dinner at the Gerhardt home that evening was a simple, though tumultuous, event. Ivan made pizzas in the oven—a Friday tradition dating back to when he'd had no free time and simply ordered them from a nearby delivery place—and had planned on settling in with his kids to watch a movie. Unfortunately, Rick's chief goal was to slip away from the family event and go off to a party with his friends. A reminder from Ivan that he was still grounded for sneaking out had gone over about as well as could be expected with a teenager.

Eventually, Rick gave up and settled in to watch the movie, an easily-forgettable comedy that left Ivan wishing he were still inclined to break the law, as he would have happily beaten his rental fee out of the actors on screen. With nothing in the movie to distract his thoughts, they inevitably wandered to the guild and what was occurring that evening.

Tori would be fine; Ivan had no worry about that. In spite of how she could come off, Xelas was dependable when the occasion truly demanded it. Not to mention she was one of the most powerful members of the guild—working hand-in-hand with Wade had elevated her technology to a place no one else on Earth would easily match. Paired with Morgana, Gork, and Stasis, no army in existence could harm the apprentices, to say nothing of the sort of things they might encounter in Ridge City. Certain capes of near demi-god level notwithstanding, of course.

Strangely enough, what Ivan found himself more concerned with was the fact that Thuggernaut and Johnny were hosting a guys' night for the other two apprentices without a single council member in attendance. Not that there weren't good reasons—Wade was far too busy, and Balaam wasn't exactly at the top of anyone's guest list—but he felt a curious pang of guilt at the fact that he could have made time for it. Ivan couldn't imagine why he cared about such an event; he'd worked as hard as he could to stay only tenuously linked to the guild. He'd probably missed countless such nights without even a single thought spared. Yet here he was, wondering if he shouldn't at least try to make an appearance.

Part of it was Tori's influence, obviously. She'd dragged him further back into the guild than anyone in years had managed; Ivan suspected that was part of why Wade tasked him with teaching her in the first place. But it

was more than just that. Now that he was partially back in, he was seeing more, knowing more, and consequently caring more.

Absentmindedly, Ivan reached out and ruffled his daughter's hair. Rick was too grown to enjoy such displays of fatherly affection, but thankfully Beth still embraced them. Ivan cared for very little in the world, but he loved his children dearly and was impossibly grateful they'd been spared from seeing his world. It was only luck and lots of planning that had kept them away from any confluences or accidents that might turn them into metas. There had been numerous occasions where, if things had gone differently, they could have been the ones found wandering the street, causing wanton destruction with their new powers. How involved would he have been if they were the ones the guild brought through that door, scared and desperate to understand what was happening, hoping against hope that they might find a way to control the unnatural abilities thrust upon them?

It was impossible to say for certain since a hypothetical was just that, but he suspected he would do more. And perhaps he still could. Only after the movie was done and his children were asleep, obviously. Helping at the guild was all well and good; however, Ivan always put his only family first. No matter what else might occur, he would protect these two above all others. That was a truth Ivan clung to, one he used to help keep his more irresponsible urges in check. It was a reason that fueled him when the rare true monster threatened to destroy the entire planet. Nothing else mattered more: not old grudges or alliances, not even working with people he hated. His children made him take up fights he would have never bothered with, and oftentimes the presence of Ivan Gerhardt had made an important difference.

Though they didn't know it, Rick and Beth had, albeit inadvertently, saved the world on several occasions.

\* \* \*

After the lively affair that was dinner, in which "Gretchen" put down five entrees in front of an astonished staff and "Alexis" ran up a three hundred dollar tab on wine, everyone piled back into the limo and headed off to the next destination. Tori knew they were going to hit a club or bar—she couldn't imagine the councilors had gotten everyone this dressed up just

to eat—but her dearth of knowledge regarding the Ridge City party scene meant she didn't recognize the glow of neon and flash of spotlights as the limo pulled up to a four-story building with a line stretching around the block.

“No freaking way,” Beverly said, staring out the window like there was gold littering the streets. “You got us into Specter Lounge? I know a dozen people who’ve tried to get in since it opened and none of them had any luck.”

“Your associates don’t have our connections,” Alexis replied cheerfully. “Let’s just say that, between money and influence, guild members don’t often bother with lines or waiting lists.”

The limo pulled to a stop next to the curb, where those stuck waiting with the faintest hope of entry watched as the six women piled out of their ride with as much grace as each could manage. This turned out to be a pretty fair amount, with the exception of Tori, who lost her balance thanks to the damn heels and nearly took a tumble to the ground. Before she’d fallen more than a few inches, a firm grip had wrapped around her shoulder and halted the descent. Alexis, her reaction-time expectedly inhuman, smiled casually as she righted Tori—a grin that said all too clearly the apprentice would be getting ridiculed for her slip once they were indoors.

Outside the limo and with both feet finally on the ground, Tori took the opportunity to get a sense of the building and was suitably impressed. It was a vast expanse of real estate, probably formerly an office building now converted for its new purpose. A silver sign rested just above the entrance, the words “Specter Lounge” lit by white neon around the letters. Spotlights from the top of the building flashed and wove intermittently, drawing the attention of everyone on the street, not just those trying to gain entry. From inside, a slight bass throb could be heard pumping through the walls.

A sharp whistle from Beverly broke Tori’s spell. She looked around to find that Lynn was leading the group up to the three bouncers who stood overseeing the line. The largest of them saw their approach and stepped forward. He met them with careful, assessing eyes, trying to figure out if they were asking an innocent question or about to make trouble. Tori couldn’t make out what Lynn said to the muscular man, who she’d have

considered more impressive if not for time spent around people like Thuggernaut, but in the span of ten seconds, his tough-guy persona melted away. In its place was a man who could not have been more accommodating as he pulled aside the decorative rope and pushed open the front door. Like a caged tiger, the music came bursting through the entrance, nearly bowling Tori over with its ferocity.

“Don’t worry,” Stacey assured her. “Where we’re going, it’s not nearly as bad.”

Though not at all certain what to make of such a cryptic statement, Tori followed the others as they walked forward, noting the angry whispers that rose up from the people in line. She couldn’t say she blamed them; if this were a place she actually wanted to be, it would have been infuriating to watch others stroll in so casually. Then Tori was through the door and all thoughts of the world outside or the people still in line completely vanished from her mind.

Specter Lounge was decorated entirely in a scheme of silver, white, and purple. Those hues ran through the entire establishment, from the numerous bars stationed throughout the area, to the massive dance floor that occupied almost the entirety of the ground floor, to the DJ booth overlooking all the writhing bodies, to the three upper floors that provided a panoramic view of the giant orgy of motion that occurred below.

Even more striking than the place itself were the people inside. Tori had felt a bit overdressed at dinner, but now she felt like she’d wandered into a fashion show wearing sweats and a stained t-shirt. Every person she saw was dressed like they were about to step onto a runway. Most were so stunning and sculpted that her brain soon overloaded and lost the ability to distinguish between them. People were wearing designer everything, outfits that cost more than her old motorcycle—and that wasn’t even counting the high-dollar accessories.

Stacey’s gentle hand on her shoulder guided Tori away from the entrance, bringing her back to reality while simultaneously steering her to their next destination. A few feet away from the front door, guarded by a pair of men that were slimmer than the bouncers yet immediately recognizable as more dangerous, was a silver elevator. Again, Lynn said

something Tori couldn't hear over the music pounding through her ears, and again the guards parted cordially. All six women easily fit inside the spacious elevator, and when the doors shut, Tori found herself overcome with the sudden crush of silence.

"Thank goodness," she muttered, her own voice sounding strange to her battered ears. "I felt like I was taking another one of those silver-cored robots' sonic attacks by the end."

"Yeah, they keep it pretty unwelcoming on the first floor," Alexis agreed. "No idea why, but somehow that makes it all the more exclusive. I tell you, the things these places pull, yet somehow we're the criminals."

"Fortunately, the VIP areas offer much more enjoyable accommodations." Lynn pressed the number four on the elevator's panel, which it lit up after a moment. The elevator began to move. "Of course, such areas are highly restricted. Generally, only the extravagantly wealthy and famous are allowed up to the fourth floor."

Stacey chuckled darkly to herself. "There's no movie star on earth better known than some of us. I'd say we definitely fit the famous part."

"Don't be silly, those are the old versions of us," Lynn corrected. "Tonight, we are merely well-connected, which I find to be far more enjoyable than infamy ever was."

The ding of the elevator's arrival interrupted their conversation, doors sliding open to reveal more guards. This pair quickly stepped aside, revealing a sprawling area that visibly wrapped around the open section in the middle of the building. True to Lynn's word, the music was greatly reduced this high, turning more to background noise than an overpowering presence. Tori suspected the club had implemented carefully-designed acoustics to achieve such an effect; the odd shape of the walls was all the confirmation she required.

This area had the same color scheme as the ground floor, though that was one of the few similarities they shared. Here, clusters of seats were carefully grouped together, tables full of various mixers and liquors set on each one. Tori didn't deal much with the club scene, but she knew enough to understand what bottle service was, along with the fact that it was

idiotically expensive. Then again, they were probably on Doctor Mechaniac's tab tonight, and billionaires had the luxury of making such indulgences. She hoped everyone else up there had a similar fiscal situation, otherwise it was shamefully wasteful.

While by no means deserted, the top floor of the club was hardly at full capacity either. Scanning the tables already in use, Tori was surprised to recognize a few of the faces present. One had been on a sci-fi show she grew up loving, another was a famous anchorman who did war correspondence, and one was someone she was pretty certain she'd seen plastered on billboards selling hand cream. It was curious to see the familiar in such a strange place, and as she turned her head to keep scanning the room, Tori saw a face she knew well. Much too well, in fact.

She felt her stomach twist at the realization that her two separate worlds were about to collide. Sadly, her stomach didn't share this information with her mouth, which spat out words of surprise before she could even consider trying to slip by unseen.

"Holy shit. Donald?"

## Chapter 46

Every ounce of residual annoyance Donald felt toward Barney and Jessica for making him dress nicely evaporated the moment he heard Tori's voice say his name. Turning in his chair, he nearly fell over at the sight of her. She'd always been pretty—he'd noticed that on the first day she walked into the office—but there was also a bit of tension that seemed to constantly linger in her, as if she were too aware of her actions and speech. Whether it was the clothes, the makeup, or the company, something had lightened her mood, and with an aura of cheer around her, Tori was so beautiful it nearly took his breath away. It certainly stole his mind, as he gazed at her for several dumbfounded seconds until a very light kick on the shin from Ren reminded him that words were appropriate in this situation.

"Tori? Wow, I didn't expect to see you until Monday." Donald rose from his chair, oblivious to the people taking notice of his movements as they would note any recently debuted superhero. Before his brain could fully kick back into gear and nix the idea, he gave her a brief, friendly hug. After they parted, he finally got a good look at the five other women with her and began to wonder just how a meeting like this was possible.

"I thought you were in the hospital," Donald said, noting the analytical stares Tori's friends were giving him.

"Oh... yeah. I was. Got out today, decided to go celebrate. You know, seeing death makes you want to live life, that sort of thing. These are..." Tori's brain raced, trying to think of a plausible reason she'd have to be hanging out with five distinctly gorgeous women in the VIP room of an exclusive club. She jumped on the first thought that popped into her head, which was part of the backstory Ivan had spun for her all those weeks ago.

"These are my friends from the program. The mandatory one. That I go to on weekends."

Donald knitted his eyebrows together in confusion; then, all at once, comprehension set in. "Oh! Right. The, um, the... thing."



“It’s okay, Donald, you can say drugs.” Without a moment of hesitation, Lynn stepped forward, taking his hand and giving it a firm shake. “I’m Dr. Faye, but please call me Lynn. I’m the group’s supervisor. You must be one of Tori’s coworkers.”

“Yes, ma’am. We’re cubicle neighbors,” Donald confirmed.

“How lovely. Well, these are my other patients: Alexis, Beverly, Gretchen, and Stacey. Tonight, everyone is out for a night of proving to themselves that they don’t need drugs to have fun.”

The other women nodded, seemingly unbothered by having their business put on display. Tori, however, looked like she wanted to dig a hole and climb inside. While Donald searched for something to say, one of the other women—Alexis, he was fairly certain—clapped Lynn on the shoulder.

“No drugs, no doubt about that, but booze is still on the table, right, doc? I didn’t use my father’s connections to get us in here for nothing.”

Lynn frowned slightly but gave a nod of her head. “While I don’t recommend it, controlled, carefully monitored drinking is all right, since none of you have any history of alcoholism.” She turned back to Donald and gave a small shrug. “This is a readjustment group, and part of that process is allowing them to define their own limitations.”

“Donald, who’s your friend?” Tori asked, less out of curiosity and more out of a desire to get her supposed drug-abuse history out of the limelight.

Spinning around, Donald realized that Ren had gotten up from their couch to join the group and was now waiting patiently to be noticed. “Crap, I’m so sorry. Everyone, this is my friend Ren. We know each other from... the gym.”

As soon as Donald finished speaking, he knew he’d made a mistake. Six sets of mascaraed eyes told the clear story that they weren’t buying his shit. While Ren looked like he probably lived in a gym, Donald would have been out of place even changing the towel bins. Even Ren seemed surprised by the explanation, which didn’t help sell the story in the slightest. Donald fumbled, trying to think of a more believable reason that would also

account for the lie, but, fortunately for both of them, Ren was a little more composed under pressure.

“Donald, it’s okay, you don’t need to be embarrassed,” Ren said before facing the women. “We’re actually in the same raiding party in *Legacy World*. I just moved to town for work, and Donald was nice enough to offer to show me around. He’s a little skittish about admitting that we’re friends from an online game, though.”

Unlike the gym lie, this went over almost without question, as it was easy to believe Donald was the sort who’d spend hours playing around in the digital world. The only one who found it suspicious was Tori; she’d worked with Donald long enough to know he was anything but shy about his love of the MMO. It was an issue she might have pressed if she weren’t so concerned with keeping her own lie undiscovered.

“So, Donald and Ren,” Alexis said, sliding forward while carefully avoiding touching either of them. “I know how we got up here. What’s your deal? One of you invent a search engine or something?”

Tori’s stomach, finally recovered from the shock of seeing Donald in such a strange environment, fell through the floor. In all the oddness of seeing a coworker while out with her guild-mates, she’d nearly forgotten why she hadn’t seen Donald all week in the first place. While she was supposed to be in the hospital, he’d no doubt been getting settled in at his new job... with the Alliance of Heroic Champions.

The slender hope she held out that Donald would be too modest to mention it evaporated as Ren threw an arm around his friend’s shoulder and proudly proclaimed, “Guess you folks haven’t been watching the news. My buddy here single-handedly stopped an attack on his office last week. He got scooped up by the AHC within hours.”

“Wait,” Beverly said, her eyes darting back and forth between Donald and Tori. “You mean he’s...”

“That’s right,” Ren confirmed. “Standing before you is one of Ridge City’s newest professional superheroes.”

\* \* \*

On the far side of the fourth floor, across the open space that looked down on the dance area, sat a man with kaleidoscope eyes, all but bathing in the awkwardness of the scene unfolding across the way. He shouldn't have been there, of course, as he was not a VIP, or at least not the sort that was ushered into high-end lounges. He also shouldn't have been able to see or hear what was occurring with any clarity, but Nexus had long ago learned how to extend the range of his senses with a few pinhole-sized rips in dimensional space. It was fascinating to see the budding metas squirm as they met each other on unfamiliar ground, both spinning lies as quickly as they could conceive of them, but it wasn't why Nexus had come out this evening.

Stasis so rarely indulged in leaving the guild headquarters; he liked to be on hand to watch what might occur when she did. This was not a habit predicated on anything about her, in particular; across infinite multiverses, she was among the few creatures that only occupied one. There were many versions of her as she'd been before, of course, yet she was the only one to transcend. The lone Stacey to become Stasis. Nexus was fascinated with all the singulars he encountered. Singulars were beyond rare, and this world hosted two of them. Nexus often wondered if Quorum's existence was part of why Stasis had survived her accident, though he'd never been able to find a tangible string of events to tie the two together. It might be chance—that was always in play—but the longer Nexus ricocheted through the multiverse, the more he found almost everything was connected in some manner or another. Occasionally, Nexus would wonder if he was, in fact, the inadvertent cause of Stasis surviving when every other version of her perished or survived unchanged. While he couldn't fathom how he might have impacted things, the potential was impossible to deny. After all, the accident that created her had been based on *his* theory and experiment.

He sipped a cosmopolitan taken from the corpse of the man who'd actually rented out this area. Around Nexus were smoldering bodies, flash-fried in a burst of heat from a dimension that was almost entirely composed of lava. Nexus had never been big on sharing his personal space. Unlike the general VIP lounge, this spot had a closed door and low lighting, making it the perfect place to sit peacefully and observe the evening's events.

As the women went over to Cyber Geek and Medley's table and had the staff bring another couch and chair over, Nexus frowned. Things weren't spinning out of control as he'd hoped. After going through so much trouble to pick a good seat, it would be a shame if there was no show to enjoy. Fortunately, Nexus was not a mere spectator. With a bit of effort, he could provide entertainment for everyone to enjoy.

It was just a matter of choosing the right props.

\* \* \*

What Tori was most taken aback by was how unfazed everyone else seemed to be by the revelation. Gretchen was quiet and stoic—no big surprise given Gork's usual personality. Alexis had clapped her hands and began fawning over Donald, asking to hear the story of how he'd saved the office. This was weird, sure, but no weirder than any of the other behaviors Xelas exhibited. Stacey seemed unbothered by the revelation—a bit bored if anything—and Lynn had merely smiled politely and complimented Donald on his prestigious position.

The only one to actually seem surprised and uncertain by the revelation was Beverly, who shot Tori a curious glance. Tori replied to with a shrug that said, "Yeah, I know it's weird. I'll explain later; this isn't the time or place to talk about it." She hoped it said that, anyway. Regardless, Beverly let the silent exchange end, following the others to the section where the guys had been camped out as Alexis had the staff bring in more chairs.

Within moments, everyone was comfortably seated, a few with drinks in their hands, as Donald regaled the table with the harrowing tale of how he'd stopped the three armed gunmen that had taken their floor of Vendallia Industries hostage. Tori noticed that Donald squirmed a bit when he got to the parts where he had to glaze over Chloe, and, by extension, her own contributions to the story, so every time he looked over, she gave him a reassuring smile. She liked that he felt guilty. Tori had never been fond of those who liked to steal glory, but ultimately this version of the story was for the best. Powers had unquestionably altered the course of her life and the lives of everyone seated around her, with the possible exception of Ren. If Chloe wanted to live as a normal person, Tori could understand why. As

fun, exciting, and tumultuous as the meta life was, it also came with a lot of danger and uncertainty. For some people, that wasn't a worthwhile trade.

"... and I managed to get off a shot to his face with my freeze-gun, which finally did the trick and knocked him out," Donald said, concluding the harrowing yarn of his triumph. "After that, things were kind of a blur. Cops came pouring in, EMTs rushed Tori and Mr. Gerhardt to the hospital, and then the last thing I could have ever expected happened. *Apollo*, of all people, showed up to help me make sense of things. He told me the AHC was impressed with what I'd pulled off and wanted to offer me a spot in their ranks. After that, it was pretty much just a press conference and paperwork."

"Wow! *The Apollo* came to court you? That's got to be something special. Your power must be really incredible." Alexis would have come off as sarcastic if not for her wide eyes and properly captivated tone. Tori was impressed with her senior's acting chops, as well as a bit surprised at how much she seemed to be enjoying her role. She also felt the slightest twinge of annoyance; even if Donald didn't know he was being mocked, Tori still did, and it felt unwarranted. Regardless of what jackasses other capes might be, Donald was just some guy who'd gotten powers tossed in his lap and was trying to do his best with them.

"It's not all that amazing," Donald replied, fidgeting nervously as Alexis inched closer to him. "Like I said, I just manifest digital objects. There are lots of way cooler powers than mine out there. I mean... did you catch that new guy, Medley, on the news? He's got some real strength, if you ask me."

"Well, strong or not, Medley wasn't the one there when our whole office needed help," Tori replied. She lifted her drink—soda with the barest splash of gin—higher than needed off the table and held it in the air. "Here's to you, Donald Moss. You saved a lot of lives that day, mine among them. I hope you get to spend the rest of your career saving many more."

The others joined in, clinking their glasses and drinking to Donald's honor. As she sipped her own, Tori wondered if there would ever come a day that she could tell Donald four members from the council ruling over a guild of villains had toasted to his good fortune as a superhero. Probably

not; in fact, she might even take a little heat for it once they were back in the limo. That was fine, though. Donald was her friend, and he deserved to feel good about what he'd done. Besides, heat was one thing Tori never had any issues handling.

"That's... strange." Ren tilted his head to the side like a dog trying to puzzle out the mysteries of a doorknob, a crease of worry appearing on his forehead. "Why are people... ?" Without another word, he rose from his seat and darted over to the edge of the railing which encircled the entire floor. The others joined him, more curious than concerned.

As she walked over, Tori realized what had caught Ren's attention. While it was hard to hear over the pumping music and carefully-designed acoustics, a new sound was emerging from the dance floor. It wasn't bass or treble or even people hollering their drink orders at overworked waitresses. No, this was something she'd heard before, and never on good occasions.

People on the dance floor were screaming. Screaming in fear, panic, and pain.

Tori peered over the railing with a gasp that escaped her lips without waiting for permission. There amid the chaos on the ground level was a bizarre creature that looked like a mix between a rhinoceros, a gorilla, and a truck. Dark, scaly armor coated nearly every part of its body as four muscular, misshaped arms reached out and snared the innocent dancers that tried to run away. Its thick, trunk-like legs cracked the ground as it moved, far too nimble for a creature of its size. It dropped screaming people into a toothy maw mere inches below the six-foot horn on its face.

"What... what the hell is that thing?" Donald was even paler than normal, no small feat for a man with his complexion, and his hands were shaking as he stared down at the monster currently murdering people by the handful.

Though the question hadn't been addressed to her and she doubtlessly didn't intend for Donald to hear the answer, Stacey still muttered a single word beneath her breath. Since she was next to Tori, it was just barely loud enough to make out each syllable, and when Tori put them together her blood ran cold.

“Nexus.”

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## Chapter 47

There was no telling how long Donald would have stood there clutching the railing and watching innocent people die if a firm, slightly painful squeeze to the shoulder hadn't brought him back to reality. Ren was staring at him as he gripped Donald's flesh, clearly waiting for something to click. But what was there? They should be safe up here, hopefully. Probably not forever, but at least until the capes arrived.

That was when it finally hit him—*they* were the capes. This mess, this monster, they were the ones who had to deal with it. No cavalry was coming because it was already there. Donald nodded—a weak, shaky gesture that made him feel slightly dizzy as he did it—and Ren let go of his shoulder. Moving more on instinct than intent, Donald unbuttoned his sleeve and yanked it up on his arm, revealing the small, black digital pad. He brushed a finger across the surface and the device hummed to life. A half-dozen categories were there to greet him. He clicked on the very first one: weapons. He needed something to stop that monster, and something told him a freeze-gun wouldn't cut it this time.

“Donald?” Tori was looking at him, clearly worried. He wasn't sure if it was for her own safety or for his, as even he knew he must look like a wreck. “What are you doing?”

Donald took a deep breath, trying to force himself to calm down. If he panicked, if the cape lost his composure, then everyone else would too. Beyond his responsibility to keep them safe, he also had to make them feel safe, even if he was lying out of his ass. That was part of what it meant to be a superhero.

“I'm grabbing something to deal with the rhino-monster down there,” Donald said, much louder than he needed to for Tori to hear. It wasn't just for her; it was for all of the others up on their floor, the scared men and women who'd just been forcibly reminded of how very mortal they all were. He skimmed through the digital display, looking for an item with high damage that would still give him a controlled shot. Power was



useless if it caught innocent people in the crossfire. It took three screens, but Donald found what he needed. A spark of blue electricity came from his hand as he pulled the item out of the screen, out of the game program running in the interface's background and into the real world.

"The Buster Burster Blaster should handle this." Donald nearly fell backward under the weight of the massive gun, almost as long as he was tall, but he managed to keep his balance long enough to rest the edge of it on the railing. Peering through the eyepiece in the back, Donald suddenly felt a wave of familiar comfort wash over him. The display was just like in *Blaster Brahs*, only this time, he was the first person whose perspective was being used. With a flick of the wrist, he cycled through the settings, choosing the plasma ray and locking on to the massive target below. Of all the elements the gun fired, this would be the most precise. Plus, it had a massive damage output, even if the cool down cycle was annoying. It would be okay, as long as Donald could end this in one shot.

"Here goes everything," he muttered under his breath. Exhaling slowly, he squeezed the trigger, a soft whir of gadgetry filling the air just before the plasma beam cut through it.

Though Donald was the one firing, it was everyone else in the room who got the best view of what happened. A blinding white light tore from the oversized gun, heading directly for the creature's torso. At the last instant, displaying more speed than anyone would have believed if they hadn't seen it, the monster turned to the side. With this new angle, the beam struck the creature just to the right of its shoulder. The beam hit the dark, chitinous armor and for a moment, the plasma ray was actually stopped. Less than a second later, a loud crack filled the air, followed by an inhuman roar from the beast. As the beam thinned and vanished, one of the creature's arms fell to the ground with a mighty thud, dark orange blood trickling out from the stump.

"Well, it stopped eating people," Alexis said from behind him. She was right, too. The alien rhino-monster wasn't attacking random dancers anymore. Now its attention was solely focused on the gun that had taken its arm and, of course, the red-headed man shakily holding it. With two steps forward, it reached up a giant hand, gripped the edge of the second floor, and began to climb.

“Shit... shit, you all need to get out of here.” Donald pulled away from the gun, only pausing to check the remaining cool down time. It would be over a minute before he could get off another shot, and at the rate the thing moved, he wasn’t sure he’d live that long. “Ren, get everyone to safety.”

“Yeah, your buddy slipped out of here while you were fiddling with your tablet,” Alexis told him.

“Why would he—”

The familiar roar from below answered Donald’s question before he’d fully formed it. A glance over the railing confirmed that Ren, now back in his furry glory as Medley, was charging across the bloody dance floor. He leapt onto the creature’s back. His claws, always so sharp, were scratching ineffectually on its hard armor, causing annoyance rather than pain. Still, it was enough to make the monster swat at him, which slowed its ascent. At this point, Donald would take whatever good fortune he could come by.

“Tori,” Donald spun his head around before realizing that she was directly next to him, giving himself a small fright in the process. “Tori, can you get everyone out of here? I don’t think they want to be around when that thing arrives, but with it up here, you should all be safe to evacuate out through the front doors.”

“And what about you?” Tori shot back. “I highly doubt that thing is coming up here to shake your hand and compliment you on the good shot.”

No, it was coming up here to kill him. He knew that—hell, everyone in the room knew that—and honestly, Donald suspected that it would likely succeed. But he couldn’t admit that fact. Not to the scared civilians, not to Tori, and most importantly, not to himself. If he did, his resolve would break, and he’d end up putting everyone else in danger. So Donald dug deep within himself, reaching all the way back to when he was a child watching the capes beat impossible odds time after time. Donald looked at the situation through the eyes of that naïve kid who truly believed good would always triumph and asked himself a single question.

What would Lodestar say?

“You’re right, it’s coming to try and kill me.” Donald hefted the gun up from the railing, walking with more confidence than he felt and resetting his perch with the barrel of the mighty machine propped against the top of a couch. “But it’s going to find me waiting for it with another hot blast of plasma, and this time, I’ll take more than a shoulder.”

Tori stepped slightly forward, but Beverly caught her arm. Eyes darting between her friends, the strangers cowering in fear, and Donald, Tori finally locked eyes with him once more. “Are you sure about this?”

“I’ve got this under control. Just get everyone to safety. Trust me: I’m a superhero.”

“Looks like you really are. Credit where it’s due, kid, I’ve known worse superheroes than you.” This came from Alexis, whose bubbly, vacant expression had completely vanished. In its place was the gaze of a woman who had lived too long and seen too much, a bizarre juxtaposition with her youthful appearance. Then it was gone, and she whirled around, letting out a high-pitched whistle. “Monster is coming, morons. Everyone out the fucking door unless you want my heel up your ass.”

For a split second, no one moved, so Alexis grabbed the person nearest to her—a minor TV celebrity—and shoved him forward. “Are you deaf as well as talentless? I said MOVE IT!”

The shove and the scream did the trick. Everyone began rushing for the stairs that sat on the opposite side of the room from the elevator. Gretchen and Lynn stood near the door, forcing people to go through one at a time so a jam wouldn’t impede their escape. In seconds, the floor had emptied, with Tori and Beverly being the last to go. Donald breathed a sigh of relief as he watched Tori vanish into the stairwell, noticing that she did pause to throw one last look at him. If he was going to have to die tonight, he’d prefer to do it alone.

Of course, dying wasn’t exactly Plan A.

As a massive hand wrapped around the edge of the railing, Donald stuck his eye back on the viewer. Only a couple of seconds left and he’d have another shot. It was close, but Medley had bought enough time.

They weren't out of this fight yet.

\* \* \*

"Are we going to do something?" Tori demanded. Beverly was beside her, and the four council members had stopped on the landing just above the next floor's exit. The panicked scuffle of bodies hurrying to freedom masked their conversation, which was good because Tori wasn't in the mood for covert whispers.

"We are doing something," Stacey replied. "We're getting out of here like your buddy wanted. Just waiting for things to thin out a bit." Though she'd affected her usual disinterested tone, it was clear Stacey was bothered by what was going on. Or, more likely, by the man they believed to have caused it.

"I meant about Donald. That thing is going to tear him to bloody chunks if we don't help." Tori glanced back up the stairs, even though they were too far down to see any of what was happening on the fourth floor.

"What do you suggest we do?" Stacey asked. "Go bust out our powers, our very well-known and distinctive powers, to save the very people who would try to haul us off to Rookstone if given half a chance?"

"Donald wouldn't do that," Tori protested.

"Tonight? Probably not, but sooner or later, he would," Stacey countered. "It's inevitable. They all turn out that way, caring more about the prestige than the good they do. Maybe it's better that he dies tonight; at least he'll get to go out while he's still the genuine article."

Tori threw the punch before she even realized she'd made a fist. It connected perfectly with Stacey's jaw, and then stopped completely. It wasn't like Tori had hit a wall or someone super strong. It was like she'd just thrown the energy of the punch away; it vanished as soon as it met Stacey, who smiled at Tori's suspended attack.

"Well, well, our little rookie has some guts to her. You're lucky I like guts. A different member of this guild would tear your spine out for that." Stacey calmly reached up, grabbed Tori by the forearm, and lowered her fist. Tori tried to resist, but it was pointless. Stacey wasn't strong: she

was inevitable, as though every movement of her body was the orbit of a planet, too tremendous to even entertain the idea of halting it. “But I think you’ve forgotten something pretty important here: we’re not the good guys. We don’t jump in whenever people are in danger. We take care of ourselves and our own. End of story. If you wanted to run around playing hero, you should have signed up with the AHC.”

Stacey released her grip on Tori’s arm just as the sound of another blast filled the air. This time the screech of the monster was so loud it rattled their teeth. It sounded pissed and definitely hurt, but not dead. Not dead was bad. Bad for the club, bad for anyone who didn’t get out, and most immediately, bad for Donald.

“I thought we were also supposed to defend our turf.” Tori was grasping at straws and she knew it, but the idea of leaving a friend behind was too much. If she was ever going to get a good night’s sleep again, she had to at least try her best to save him. “Someone either just unleashed or turned into a monster in a club with four of the guild’s councilors. That sure seems like an act of aggression to me, the sort of thing our terrifying and powerful guild should mount a response to.”

“Oooh, going for the pride *and* the politics, now that’s a nice move,” Alexis said, leaning against the concrete wall and gazing down the stairs as people flooded out. “Pseudonym wouldn’t have had the patience for that play.”

“Whose side are you on?” Stacey snapped.

“Whoever’s is more interesting,” Alexis replied. “And, on a personal level, while I loathe almost all the capes out there, the ones like that kid aren’t so bad. He knew he was probably going to die, and he still tried to get us all to safety without making us worry. That type, I don’t mind so much.”

“Oh, great, then you and the rookie can both go up there to save everyone.” Stacey turned, her stoic mask slipping to show the fear and frustration ripping through her. “And then when that insane fuck lets loose three more monsters, you can kill those too. Then fight back the lava, or the tundra, or whatever else comes because you can’t *beat* Nexus, you idiots. All you can do is wait until he gets bored.”

For a moment, there was silence, punctuated by the thump of something hitting the wall upstairs. When Lynn finally spoke, it was with the same measured, calm voice she'd affected while pretending to be the group's doctor, a facade Tori was quickly realizing might be more truth than fiction.

"Enough. Tori, I understand he's your friend, but the AHC has their own way of handling things. Stacey, we all know you and Nexus have a complicated history, but please don't antagonize our rookie, who is only worried about a friend's safety. Alexis... well, I'd ask you to stop stirring the pot, but those would be wasted words. Now, we're all going to get out of here, right now, and anyone who wants to argue more can do so once we're back in the limo."

"But I—"

"Tori," Lynn said, cutting her off before a new argument could begin. "Your friend has chosen a very difficult path. It will be fraught with peril just like this. Unless you plan to follow Donald around and fight his battles for him, you have to accept that he's going to end up in danger more often than not." Lynn walked over and set a reassuring hand on the apprentice's head, gently stroking her hair. "Much as we might have our quarrels with the AHC, they are not in the habit of giving such attention to weak metas. Try believing in Donald instead of worrying about saving him. If given the chance, he might just surprise you."

"If it'll make you feel better, I've hacked into the security cameras," Alexis said. "He's not dead yet, but things are getting interesting. I can put it on the screens in the limo, once we get there."

"Yeah. Please. I should watch, if nothing else." Tori wasn't certain if she'd just agreed to be a witness to her friend's death or his unlikely triumph. All she knew was that if these were Donald's final moments of life, someone should see them.

## Chapter 48

In spite of logic, odds, and all belief in a practical universe, Donald Moss wasn't yet dead. He darted to the other side of the room, barely dodging one of the monster's grabbing hands as it tried to snap his bones and turn him into food. The monster, now less one horn thanks to a plasma blast that was just a bit too early, thundered about, trying to snare the vulnerable human flesh in its murderous claws.

Donald, still dragging the massive gun, was barely able to avoid the attack. The reverberation as the beast hit the wall shook the very floor beneath his feet. Though shooting off the horn had been an accident, Donald had started to suspect it was actually a stroke of luck. The grace that this rhino-like beast had displayed down below was suddenly absent, leading him to theorize that the horn somehow served to help it balance the unwieldy bulk of its body. This made dodging difficult but still doable.

On the other side of the room, Medley slowly rose to his feet, and Donald breathed a small sigh of relief. When the monster had hurled his friend against the wall, leaving a massive dent in the stone material, Donald had feared the worst. Luckily, Medley was far hardier than most and was slowly shaking off the worst effects of the blow. Unluckily, the time he was taking to regain his wits meant Donald was on his own, running away from a clumsy, angry, deadly monster intent on turning him to pulp.

"You okay?" Medley called, his powerful voice barely audible over the cacophony of stomping monster.

"*Do I look fucking okay?*" Donald screeched as he hurled himself to the side, nearly losing a grip on the gun, his greatest asset and liability all rolled into one slowly recharging package. Though there was no time to glance in the eyepiece, he estimated that it had to be nearly recharged by now. Not that it mattered—it was taking everything he could to get away from this damn creature. Lining up a shot was out of the question. If only he could actually lift the thing, maybe he'd have a better chance of connecting. Of course, the pressure of knowing that without a power-up, the gun had a

three-shot limit certainly didn't help matters. If he did get another shot, it would be the last one.

With a shake of his head, tossing his mane like it was caught in the wind, Medley reared back and charged at their opponent. This time he didn't bother grabbing on to its back; the armor there was too thick, and its unnaturally jointed arms could still easily reach him. Instead, he took advantage of its missing horn and launched himself right at its face. Using his own claws to grip the scarce amount of exposed flesh, Medley snapped and tore at the area that appeared to be its eyes, a small open patch barely visible under the armored ridge of its brow.

As a gamer, Donald knew a delay tactic when he saw one. Mounting the end of the gun against the edge of a sofa once more, he peered into the viewer and readied himself to take aim. Unfortunately, what greeted him was not the aiming mechanism that would help him lock on to his target, but a timer that was just going down past the thirty-second mark. Shit, had it really only been a minute since the last shot? Time flew when one was dodging for their life, apparently.

Medley let out a sound between a whimper and a roar as the monster's claws raked across his back. While Medley had some scaly armor of his own, it wasn't nearly enough to stop those powerful arms from driving into his flesh. Donald tried to think, tried to focus on what he could still do. Medley wouldn't be able to hold out for a whole half a minute more, and when he went down this time, there was no telling how long it would be until he managed to get back up, if he managed to get back up at all. Without a distraction, Donald had zero hope of pulling off anything but a wild shot. Damn this gun! It was so stupidly heavy and cumbersome. Who had designed it like this? They'd had to add a whole special armor to *Blaster Brahs* just to explain how they wielded ...

"Medley! I need ten more seconds!" Donald wanted to smack himself on the head and feel like an idiot, but there wasn't time for self-loathing. He'd have to sneak that in later, assuming they both survived. Slapping the display on his wristband so quickly that the screen wobbled, Donald backtracked out of weapons and into the armor section. Of all the things he'd experimented with during his time by himself, it had never occurred to him to try to manifest and equip something other than handheld



items. He wasn't even sure his power worked that way, but worrying was a luxury he didn't have at the moment. Either it worked, or they probably died.

So it had damn well better work.

Finally, Donald found what he was looking for and thrust his fingers, crackling with blue sparks as usual, into the display. As he pulled the item from the digital world to his, he focused on it not only coming through, but coming through already wrapped around his weak, tender body. Closing his eyes and tossing a prayer up to any god that might listen, Donald gave the final jerk.

Lines of code suddenly turned into metal and electronics. Lifting his eyelids as slowly as he dared, Donald was overcome by a wave of excitement as he realized he was peering through the visor that topped the helmet of the Master Brah's Armor. It was all there—meters for shields, speed-boosts, even thrusters. As he pulled himself up, Donald realized he could easily lift the gun now, swinging it about one-handed, as if it weighed no more than a wooden toy. That was why the weapon was so heavy: in the lore of *Blaster Brahs*, they needed specially enhanced armor to use it. In the upper right-hand corner of his visor display, Donald noted a replication of the countdown timer. Only about fifteen seconds left to go.

From Medley's bloody gouges and tilting stance, it didn't seem like he'd last that much longer. The fact that he'd managed to hang on for so long under such a powerful assault spoke volumes about the determination that lived in Ren Tanaka. Donald was impressed—wowed, to be honest—and made a mental note to buy Ren a beer once things were settled.

“Get clear! I'm on this.”

For a moment, it seemed like Medley was going to hang on anyway, determined to go down swinging. But Medley understood enough about guns to know that being in the way when a giant plasma beam fired was a futile gesture. After a moment of scouting for the best path of exit, he leapt between the monster's swinging arms, which were intent on slicing him to pieces, and landed deftly on the carpet fifteen feet away.

As soon as Donald saw his friend go, he charged forward. He still had ten seconds left, but he'd be damned if he was going to let Medley buy them in blood. It was time to stop hiding—behind Ren, behind Chloe, behind Tori. He'd told the world he was a superhero, that he could be counted on to save the day. Ten seconds and one more shot; that was his window to prove it.

Between the adrenaline, fear, and relentless pressure of having something unworldly trying to kill him, Donald moved almost entirely on instinct. It was like he was in the hardest part of the game, difficulty settings cranked up as high as they would go. Thought failed to exist; it would only slow him down. Donald didn't even know how he'd activated the armor's speed-boost, shooting backward at the last second as he avoided a powerful blow. Fragments of couch flew toward him, striking the armor's shields and slightly lowering their value. The speed-boost gauge had also been drained, over a third gone from that one move alone.

For the first time, it occurred to Donald that merely loading the games and items onto a wrist-sized computer display hadn't done dick in the way of leveling them. He was basically playing with starter gear. Contrary to how that news should have hit him, Donald smiled as he speed-boosted back from another blow, bright blue flames shooting out of his back as they carried him away. Sure, he'd have liked a little more oomph in his weaponry, but he hadn't spent most of his adult life playing games because he shied away from a challenge. Real life had always been terrifying. Deep down, he knew he should be a quivering mass of fear at what was happening around him. But he wasn't. Maybe it was the digital display that made things seem just a bit unreal. Maybe it was the cocktail of adrenaline and worry soaking his brain. Maybe he had just gone too far into terror and become momentarily numb to it.

All he knew was that as he used the last of his speed-boost gauge to avoid a set of claws that would have cut him to ribbons, Donald realized he was actually having fun. It certainly didn't hurt that as his speed gauge went empty, the numbers in the upper right-hand of his visor ticked down to zero. Suddenly, the targeting system came online. Donald raised his gun and saw the now-hornless monster light up like it was the only thing in the room.

Unfortunately, it wasn't just raw muscle and violence; it had learned what Donald raising that gun meant. The beast charged forward, determined to crush him before he was able to get off another shot. Donald's heart was slamming in his chest so loudly that he could hear the blood rushing through his ears. He tried to think of a way out. No speed-boosts left, and if chair debris drained his shields, then they had no shot of surviving a direct hit from the rhino-monster. Normal dodging was out, and so was standing his ground, which left Donald with only one option. Granted, it was an option that had very little chance of succeeding, but after cheating death so many times in such a short span, Donald felt like he was on a roll. Might as well make the big bet while riding a hot streak.

With a mighty leap that would have made Medley proud, Donald jumped straight over the railing that ran around the fourth floor and into the open air above the dance area. As soon as he was airborne, he kicked on the armor's thrusters. It couldn't fly, technically, but the Master Brah's armor did have the ability to hover for short windows of time. In the case of unlevelled armor, that window was especially tiny—the thruster gauge on Donald's visor began dropping like it had sprung a leak. With no time to spare, he spun in the air, locking his weapon directly on to the alien creature as it slammed into the wall where he'd been standing.

For a moment, just one precious moment amid the chaos of the evening, the creature was stunned by a combination of surprise and impact. It was exactly the chance Donald had been waiting for. He fired the last plasma beam without hesitation, striking right in the monster's center mass. The armor held as before for just an instant and then the beam was through, boring a hole directly in its torso. Not wanting to take any chances, Donald swung the gun, the laser carving a path of burned flesh from the middle of its torso up to its alien head. The beam pattered out just before his thrusters, and suddenly Donald was freefalling through the air.

He slammed into the ground, the shields saving him from some, but not all, of the impact. To his surprise, the armor dissolved into flashing numbers and sparks of electricity as soon as the shield gauge hit empty. Seconds later, the gun, flashing a red light on its side that indicated it was out of shots, did the same. Donald had never seen that happen before, but he'd also never completely used up or broken any of the digital items he

brought over. Surprising as it was, the disappearing gear was the lowest possible item on his list of priorities.

Donald sprawled on the dance floor, listening to the music still somehow blasting through the air, and waited. His back ached and his ears were already starting to hurt from being so close to the speakers, but he didn't dare move a muscle. Not until he knew for sure that the fight was over. If that thing was alive, if he'd failed to hit any vital organs, Donald wasn't sure what moves he had left. Wait peacefully for death seemed the most likely, but after fighting this hard to live, he somehow doubted he had it in him to just lie down and die, no matter that he was already lying down.

Finally, the furry head of Medley popped over the railing's edge. He yelled something down but Donald was in a crush of bass—no mere words could cut through. When Donald failed to reply, Medley quickly put two and two together. Rather than continuing to scream, he merely held out a clawed hand with a raised thumb—the universal sign for “things are okay.”

His friend's furry thumbs-up was one of the most beautiful things Donald could ever remember seeing. He returned the gesture with one of his own, letting Medley know that he was bruised, not broken. Then, to no one's surprise more than his own, Donald let out a whoop of unfettered joy. On its heels came laughter, nervous and wonderful and paired with tears, which Donald wouldn't notice until several minutes later.

They'd done it. They hadn't just survived, they'd stopped the monster. Maybe he'd exaggerated his way into the AHC; maybe he didn't really have what it would take to be a big-name cape; maybe tonight was just a fluke. But tonight, none of that mattered. He'd still managed to do the job.

Tonight, Donald Moss was a superhero.

## Chapter 49

“Come on now, even we have to admit that was pretty cool,” Alexis said, refilling her glass of champagne.

Thanks to her and Gretchen shoving people aside, they’d made it back to the limo just in time to watch Donald summon his armor. Tori sat, mouth wide open in amazement at what she’d just witnessed. Donald, *Donald* of all people, had just pulled that off? It hadn’t felt like she was watching her coworker at all. Had she not known better, Tori would have guessed she was witnessing the fight of a real, true-blue cape.

Which, now that she thought about it, she sort of had been.

“Good for you,” Tori said, eyes still on the screen as Donald laughed himself to tears amid the blaring music.

“He fought bravely,” Gretchen agreed.

Lynn cleared her throat and shot a look to Alexis, who took the cue and turned off the video feed. With the limo once more silent, she moved to a position near the front where everyone could see her.

“Though tonight was planned to be more fun than educational, it seems fate intervened and gave us a teaching moment after all,” Lynn said. “Capes are not, in and of themselves, our enemies. We do not antagonize them; in fact, much of the code is based around staying out of their way. We can even respect them, on a personal level, if we deem them to be strong or worthwhile in a way we acknowledge. Friendship is... well, not unheard of, but certainly a bit tough. Nonetheless, Tori, I’m glad you didn’t have to bury a friend tonight. With all of that said, can either of you apprentices guess why Alexis was monitoring the feed before anyone asked her to?”

“She wanted information,” Beverly replied, no hesitation in her voice. “Those guys are new to the AHC, right? Medley popped up this week, and Tori’s friend only came on last Friday. In case they survived, she—no, the guild would want to know what they could do.”

“Precisely.” Lynn turned to Tori, who’d suspected that to be the reason even if she didn’t want to say it out loud. “So, using that information, Tori, if Donald were to come up on you while in costume and on a job and catch you red-handed, what methods would you use to avoid capture?”

Tori opened her mouth to reply then closed it a second later. Her first instinct was to assume Lynn was asking how she’d kill Donald, but that hadn’t been the question. In fact, the guild emphasized evasion over engagement at pretty much every turn. Mentally flipping back through the fight, she realized that they now all knew of a very easy way to slow him down long enough to slip away.

“I’d blast his armor until it dissolved, then run away before he was able to reform it,” Tori replied at last. “Since the gun died too, there’s probably a limit to how much he can use his items. If I could dodge them long enough and slip away before he had the chance to reload, I could take off my costume and just be regular Tori again.”

“Which addresses why costumes are mandatory,” Lynn said, giving Tori a slight nod. “Yes, that would be a viable option. In contrast, you also now know that the one called Medley has exceptional recovery abilities. Nothing short of extreme damage is likely to take him down, and even then, only for a short while. This means he can be dealt with more firmly without risk of killing him.”

Lynn took a glass of champagne from the bar and carefully sipped its contents. “Remember, unless you are specifically authorized by the council, killing a cape is to be avoided at all costs. They get angry when their own die, just as we do, and that anger can lead to problems for the entire guild. Much of why we gather information is so that, should engagement become unavoidable, we can slip away without doing lasting harm. Control and precision are far more crucial to our survival than mere power.”

“Of course, when the need does arise, and the council gives that permission, it also helps to know what their weaknesses are,” Alexis added. “Though you won’t have to worry about that for a long while. Killing

capas, especially covertly, isn't easy, and it definitely isn't something we saddle rookies with."

"When do you kill them?" Tori asked. "I've had to learn the code backwards and forwards, and I've yet to see a clause outlining when we knock off superheroes."

"It's covered under the 'threats to guild security' section," Stacey told her. "If the council feels a cape is stirring things up too much, focusing on coming after us instead of the people who aren't so careful with their crimes, then we try to dissuade them. First politely, then less so."

"It doesn't happen often," Lynn said. "Nowadays, the AHC largely plays along with the peace. In the early days, things were less stable. But none of the capas in charge are gung-ho about coming after us. They know the gain isn't worth the loss, so they usually squish any attempts by others to get on our bad side."

"If it ever did come down to a fight between us and them, who do you think would win?" Beverly asked. She seemed oddly interested in the idea, a fact that Tori filed away for consideration at a later date.

"No one knows," Gretchen said.

"Yeah, we'll talk a lot of shit in front of the masses, but at the end of the day, it's a toss-up," Alexis added. "They've got more people than we do, but we have more major league hitters than they do. People who get the insane, world-changing powers are more likely to seek self-betterment than saving the world. It would be a good fight, but there's no way to predict the winner."

"Which is why we work so hard to avoid it," Lynn said. "Win or lose, an all-out war between us and the capas would shatter the enjoyable lives we've built for ourselves. No one, at least no one in the guild, wants to go back to being wanted fugitives with our faces plastered everywhere. Not when we can have champagne, VIP lounges, and limos along with anonymity."

"War: the only way to win is not to play." Tori wasn't sure that everyone would get the *War Game* quote, but the casual nodding and smiles

told her that at least the sentiment had made it through.

“Exactly,” Lynn agreed. She reached up and knocked gently on the divider between them and the robo-driver. Seconds later, the car smoothly pulled into motion. “Which is why we stay out of their business, they stay out of ours as long as we don’t flaunt it, and everyone wins. The people get peace, the capes get acclaim, and we are about to go get some cheesecake.”

Weird monster fights and cheesecake weren’t exactly how Tori had expected the night to end, but, given the company she was with, things certainly could have turned out worse.

\* \* \*

The soft sound of palms striking one another snapped Donald to attention. The hair on the back of his neck stood on end as he readied himself for another fight. The sound repeated itself, and again, and again, and he finally realized what it was. Apollo was standing in the door of the infirmary, giving him a slow clap that was gradually picking up speed. From anyone else, he might have taken it to be sarcastic, but the beaming grin on Apollo’s face made it all too clear how sincere the applause was.

“You, Donald Moss, are full of surprises,” Apollo said, walking through the door and sitting down next to the tank of goo Donald was currently submerged in. Supposedly, it rapidly accelerated the healing process and minimized long-term damage—an invention Professor Quantum had come up with some time before. All Donald knew was that from the moment he’d been put inside, his back had stopped hurting, which was no small feat since it was bruised from his neck to his ass.

“I have to tell you, when I heard that there had been a dimensional rip with an unfriendly breaking through, I assumed the worst. Then they told me it was at the club where we sent you and Medley, and all I could think was that I hoped you got the call out for backup in time. But you and Ren, you didn’t even need backup, did you? The two of you handled an Epsilon Class inhuman presence on your own, and that is impressive. Damned impressive, if you want to know the truth.”

“We caught some lucky breaks,” Donald admitted. Much as he enjoyed the praise, it felt a little excessive to accept wholeheartedly. The



last thing he wanted was for Apollo to think he could handle that sort of fight regularly.

“Oh, there’s no question about that. I’d say seven out of ten times, that thing would have torn you both apart,” Apollo agreed. Despite the seemingly negative words, his cheer didn’t dim. If anything, it seemed to increase. “But three out of ten is much better odds than I’d give the majority of the rookies we’ve got right now. With time and training, each of you will be able to smoke something like that single-handedly.”

Donald couldn’t imagine ever being that powerful; however, before tonight he couldn’t have imagined himself going toe-to-toe with a giant alien monster in real life either. He was starting to think his imagination was going to have to expand its limits, though he wasn’t too keen on testing Apollo’s assertion anytime soon.

“Let’s hope I get a long while before I have to try soloing anything of that level,” Donald replied. “What was that creature, anyway? Another meta-human?”

“Maybe, in the dimension where it hails from.” Apollo sat over one of the uncomfortable plastic chairs, hovering in place a few inches above the surface. “Or it might be something akin to a deer for all we know. Sometimes, for one reason or another, the walls between the dimensions bleed or outright break, and on those occasions, it’s possible for things to slip through. What you fought was one such example. Some of the smarter superheroes have tried cataloguing them, but there are more dimensions out there than there are stars in the sky, so no one has had much luck figuring out any sort of pattern in the bits we discover.”

“Do they at least know what caused the rip tonight?” Donald had an uncomfortable fear sitting in his stomach as he pictured the way he pulled his items into existence. What if he was yanking them from another dimension and in doing so was weakening the borders between them?

“Oh yes; security cameras caught a glimpse of the criminal named Nexus watching the show from a corner of the club. We had a few of our metas with dimensional abilities do a sweep and they confirmed it: he caused the rip.”

Much as he'd expected to feel relieved, Donald instead felt a new fear crystalize inside him. "Nexus is the guy who wiped out the original Denver, isn't he? Why on earth would he bother unleashing a monster in a club?"

"No one knows why Nexus does what he does." Apollo shrugged his tan, muscular shoulders in a way that seemed strange for one so blessed with authority. "He's untraceable, unpredictable, and seems to be totally insane. Sometimes he changes things in ways that help people; on other occasions he unleashes wanton destruction for no apparent reason. Maybe there was someone in the club he wanted to kill tonight. Maybe he was just interested in seeing what you two could do. Maybe they messed up his drink order, I honestly have no clue. You're better off not worrying about it too much. Think of Nexus like a force of nature: don't look for reason in the destruction he causes."

"If he's that dangerous, why hasn't the AHC stopped him?" It was something Donald had wondered even back when he was looking in from the outside, but now that he was here, inches away from Apollo himself, the question seemed even more important. They had so many metas, so many resources. Why was a maniac like that allowed to run free?

"Look, you find out a way to do that, you can pretty much write your own ticket around here," Apollo replied. "Everyone has tried to stop him, even Lodestar and Quorum. We've captured him a few times, though it never lasts, and even killed him once or twice, not that it matters. He just turns right back up. We don't know how his powers work, only that they let him open holes between dimensions. Trust me, the minute someone actually finds a way to neutralize that asshole, it will be all hands on deck."

Apollo leaned forward until he was only a few feet away from Donald's face, his eyes suddenly serious. "One thing about me, I have no tolerance for the villains of this world. It's our job to stop them, and I take that job very seriously. No matter what opinions our other members might have."

Before Donald could ask a single clarification question, the moment was past. Apollo was back to floating above his seat, ever-present grin right

back in place. It happened so quickly, Donald almost wondered if he'd imagined the whole exchange.

"But we'll talk about that later. Tonight, you just need to focus on recovery," Apollo told him, floating forward and putting his feet on the ground. "Tomorrow we're going to have a press conference and some celebration for you and Medley. You both managed to score your first big collar before we'd even put you on patrol. Rest up and make sure you're in tip-top shape."

Apollo walked to the edge of the room and looked back at Donald, the shadows from the hallway hitting his face in a way that distorted his constant smile into something almost like an insane grin.

"You need to take care of yourselves. I've got big plans for the both of you."

\* \* \*

Thuggernaut, Johnny, Arachno Bro, Pod Person, Arcanicus, and Ivan, who had slipped out once his kids were good and asleep, along with Lance and Warren, were seated around the poker table when the other apprentices and their guides walked in. Xelas—Alexis no more as she'd shed her disguise along with the others—glanced around in confusion before slapping herself on the head, causing a clank that echoed across the room.

"Shit, I forgot you had this place tonight. We'll go find another room to unwind in." Xelas turned, motioning for the others to head back down the stairs, but Johnny called to her before she got free.

"How'd your night go? Have a nice, fun outing at the club? We've been getting pretty rowdy ourselves."

Every female member of the council, along with Tori and Beverly, stared at Johnny with individual combinations of disbelief and contempt. Wordlessly, they filed back down the stairs in search of another lounge where they could drink wine, relax, and unwind from a night that had gone spectacularly off the rails. The slam of the door from downstairs was the

only cue that they'd officially left. No one even bothered to call out a goodbye.

“Guess they're jealous we had a livelier time,” Johnny said with a shrug. He threw a few more chips into the pot, hoping to bluff his way out of yet another bad hand.

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## Chapter 50

Tori was a bit surprised by the hangover that woke her up on Saturday morning. While she liked the occasional beer, she rarely drank enough to actually catch the ‘brown-bottle flu’, as her father had called it. Yet in the midst of all the craziness the night before, she’d probably put down more booze in one evening than in the rest of the month combined. It was, mercifully, an easy fix as she pulled herself out of bed and trudged toward the bathroom.

Before stepping in (making certain she was on the tile, just to be safe), she pulled off the t-shirt and shorts that served as her pajamas and turned into living fire. Regeneration was a handy aspect of her abilities, one for which she’d been constantly grateful over the years. Using it to cure a hangover might not qualify as the most noble of pursuits, but with a day of guild training ahead of her, the last thing Tori wanted was to start off sluggish.

She stood there for about five minutes before shifting back, her once more human anatomy now completely cured of any lingering hangover effects. That problem solved, she hopped in the shower, scrubbing off a night of excitement, panic, and worry. Once clean, she dried off and dressed in her apprentice costume, the default outfit for all guild endeavors. Glancing at the clock, Tori realized she was up a full hour earlier than necessary. With nothing else to do before training started, she decided to head over to the rookie lounge and grab some breakfast. It wouldn’t be as good as the stuff Ivan made, but it would be filling enough to keep her going until lunch.

When Tori walked into the large room, she immediately noticed that she wasn’t the only one with a hankering for caloric intake. Beverly, adorned in her own generic apprentice costume, sat in front of the television watching the news as she wolfed down a breakfast burrito from the vending machine. Based on the wrappers at her side, it was her third or fourth so far.

Neither said anything as Tori plunked her money in the machine, getting two burritos of her own along with a soda. Things had been a bit strange between them ever since Beverly found out Tori was friends with a cape. She'd expected that reaction from the older members, who'd turned out to be unbothered by it, but not from Beverly. Silence wasn't fixing anything though, so as Tori took a seat on the couch, she decided it was time to try the other thing: actual talking about the issue at hand.

"Are we cool?" She hated the words even as she said them, but Tori Rivas had not been blessed with the gift of subtlety. Beverly looked over at her, so she decided to just power through and get things done. "You've seemed kind of bothered since last night when you met Donald."

"Guess we had to do this eventually," Beverly muttered. She picked up the remote, turned the television on mute, and then gave her attention back to Tori. "Look, I get it. He was your buddy at work, you became friends, and then he got turned into a cape. Completely impossible to predict and nobody's fault. Well, sort of his for choosing to be one, I suppose, but I'll admit it sounds like things sort of snowballed on him. I don't have any problem with Donald as a person or you for being his friend. I just *really* dislike the AHC."

"Why? I mean, sure, we're villains and technically enemies, but you heard Morgana last night. We mostly stay out of each other's way."

Beverly shook her head. "I've disliked that place since long before I got these powers. It's part of why I stayed with the guild; I needed to learn control, and I sure as shit wasn't going to the capes to get it. Remember how I told you that the amulet I found was among my great-grandmother's knick-knacks? Well, I wasn't the first in my family to come across an artifact from her collection. My grandpa found one, a special one she'd kept tucked away in a safe almost no one knew about. It was a crown, silver and studded with three gems in the center. When he put it on, grandpa was suddenly adorned in medieval armor. He was strong, fast, could fly, and had a few other powers as well. He figured that after a lifetime of hunting and hoarding, great-grandma had actually found one item of genuine power."

"I'm guessing your grandfather joined the AHC," Tori said.

“Tried to, anyway. This was way back in the day, before Quorum and Lodestar, before the AHC was even called that. Professor Quantum was the biggest powerhouse around, and he was in charge of what was then the League of Metas. My grandpa went by there after learning how to use his powers, wanted to join up and make the world a better place. Their response was that they didn’t have a spot for him on the main roster, but they were working on a ‘Colored Division’ to do some lesser jobs and they thought he’d be a great fit.”

“Hoooooly shit.” Tori set down her breakfast burrito, appetite momentarily lost.

“Yeah. The fifties, you know? That wasn’t even the worst of it, though.” Beverly put her hands together, using each to stop the other from trembling in anger. “When he rightfully told them to go fuck themselves, guess what they said? If he didn’t want to join up, that was perfectly fine. He could leave anytime he wanted. The crown, however, stayed with them.”

“No fucking way. They couldn’t...”

“Different times,” Beverly replied. “Media was carefully controlled, and there were no internet or cell phone cameras to record that sort of thing. Grandpa hadn’t gone out and done anything heroic yet—he wanted to get training so he could be as effective as possible—so no one out there even knew he existed. Just like that, those fuckers took away the source of his power, saying it needed to be in the hands of someone who would make proper use of it. They took the heart right out of grandpa along with it. To the day he died, there always a sadness around him, like a piece of him was missing. I guess because there was.”

“God. Damn. No wonder you hate the AHC,” Tori said. “I’d be trying to light their building on fire if I were you.”

“Not going to lie, the day I discovered the red dragon power, I was a little tempted,” Beverly admitted.

“Probably for the best you didn’t, at least for now.” Tori shook her head in disbelief and picked her breakfast back up. Terrible as Beverly’s tale was, it didn’t change the fact that she couldn’t train on an empty

stomach. “Do you know what happened to the crown? Like, which cape is out there using it?”

“Strangest thing, actually,” Beverly replied. “We’ve never seen hide nor hair of anyone out there wearing it. It’s possible that the appearance is different depending on who uses it. Or maybe it only works for certain people, limited by genetics or inherent goodness or something. Trust me, if I did know who had it, I’d be beating it off the top of their head right now.”

“If that day ever comes, just let me know and I’ll hold them while you hit them,” Tori offered. “But, and please don’t hate me for saying this, that was a different organization than the AHC. I’ve got no love for capes in my heart, either, but it’s not like it was when they did that to your grandfather.”

“You know you’re talking about the same organization that has a member who flies around in a robotic Klansman’s outfit, right?”

“We all know they tried to kick out Whitest Knight,” Tori reminded her. “The lawsuit was a media circus for the full year it took. I’m not proposing we drop out of the guild and run to see if they’ll let us join, just advocating for a clear perspective when dealing with them. That kind of grudge can lead to mistakes, the sort that might end in breaking the code. And, in case you didn’t notice last night, I’m not big on the idea of seeing my friends killed.”

“I might have picked up on that. Sort of surprised me, actually. I mean, who’d have guessed that the terrifying Pseudonym’s apprentice was actually a big ole softy?” Beverly chuckled. “I’ll take the point to heart, though. I don’t plan on taking many, maybe any jobs once the apprenticeship is over, but I also didn’t plan on getting dragon powers. Best to be ready for anything.”

Beverly reached over, picked up her pile of wrappers and began smushing them together into one greasy, wadded-up ball. “And to answer your question, yeah, we’re good. It isn’t your fault you had a friend go cape, and it isn’t his fault that they did what they did to my family. I might not like the organization, but I’m trying to judge the people on a case-by-case basis.”



Leaning back, Beverly tossed her paper ball through the air, where it arced gracefully before plopping down a solid two feet away from the open trashcan where she'd been aiming. "Guess it's a good thing no one expects me to handle ranged fighting."

"Not when they've got me on hand." Tori balled up her own wrapper, took careful aim, and proceeded to miss the exact same shot, her wadded up ball landing a few inches away from Beverly's. "Well, shit. Maybe Lance has a good aim."

"We can only hope," Beverly agreed.

It was a silly, simple conversation, but by the time breakfast was done, both women felt a lot better. There were few people they could trust and lean on in a situation like theirs; losing that trust with each other would have made things much harder.

Especially as they drew closer to their goal, when they'd need to rely on the other apprentices more than ever before.

\* \* \*

"Come in!" Donald didn't bother getting up from his bed, controller still in hand as he fired several rounds into the alien hides of his attackers. From the door, an audible click could be heard as it unlocked, responding to his voice command and allowing the person outside to step through. Donald wasn't sure how he felt about every aspect of the AHC, but the accommodations they had in place were nothing to sneeze at.

"What the hell, man?" Ren pushed open the door, once again cloaked in his human illusion. Instead of a suit, he was wearing a tank top and basketball shorts, having no doubt come right from the gym. "When I asked what you were doing at breakfast, you said you were going to spend the whole day training. I've been in the gym since this morning and you haven't set foot in there."

"I'm doing a different kind of training," Donald replied. He punched the pause button, freezing the screen as his character looked over a small hill where an ambush was no doubt waiting to try and surprise him. "Last night, I noticed something that had never come up before. I explained that

the items I pull have to come from real games, right? They can't just be pieces of code."

"Yeah, that's why your fancy wrist pad has like twenty whatchabytes of memory on it. It's running a dozen or so games at once in the background."

"Exactly. Well, when they built it, they installed fresh copies of all the games. Which means all I can access are the default, unleveld versions of the items. If I'd had a fully fleshed out blaster and armor last night, I could have lit that monster up before it even managed to climb the wall."

"Your items have levels?" Ren stared at the screen, then at Donald, then at the wrist computer that sat on the floor, wires connecting it to the television screen. "I do not get you video game guys."

"Some have levels, some are just shitty until you find upgrades, and sometimes you have to play through to the end of the game to get the really cool gear," Donald explained. He held up the controller in his hand and pointed at the screen. "That's what I meant by training. I'm playing through *Blaster Brahs* so next time I can actually take a few hits and not need ninety seconds between every shot."

"Weird," Ren said. "I mean, I get it, or I think I do anyway, but it's still strange to me that you sitting in here, playing games, is going to make you stronger. Are you even sure it will work? What if you still pull the default item?"

"It took me an hour and a half to figure out how to hook up a controller and television to that thing, so I definitely made sure it was worth the time first," Donald assured him. He hopped off the bed and walked over to a small desk where his laptop, the one he'd gotten for his project at Vendallia, sat humming softly. "This morning I logged into my *Legacy World* account and created a new character. When I took a sword from him, it was just a sword, and kind of a shitty one at that. When I switched over to my usual character, I was able to pull the same sword that had gone through some serious upgrading and gem-crafting."

Donald wiggled the mouse, bringing up a screen that showed his small character sitting in a pub, head down on the table, asleep. With a few

clicks, he opened the item screen, reached over, and plucked the sword from inside the game. Ren took a step back on pure instinct. The blade in front of him was glowing with a dark purple light. Power seemed to radiate off it, occasionally appearing in short bolts that crackled between the blade and the guard.

“The upgrades definitely carry over.” Donald let go of the blade, which quickly dissolved into sparks and numbers. “Hence why I’ve been in here playing *Blaster Brahs* all morning.”

“Why not just use items from the game with the sword?” Ren asked.

“MMO’s require constant internet connections, the sort that are hard to manage wirelessly.” Donald cast a long, lingering glance at the computer screen still acting as digital portal into *Legacy World*. “Much as I’d love to pull out some of my *LW* character’s items, the wrist-unit can’t reliably connect, which means it’s too dangerous to count on them. Instead I’ve got to work with stuff I can keep offline copies of.”

Ren held up his hands in surrender. “You win. I give up. This somehow counts as training. But you still need to hit the gym sometimes. Basic strength and cardio are useful no matter what your power is.”

“Plus, who else there has the courage to spot you?” Donald closed the laptop and went back to his bed. Nice as it was to hang out here, he was looking forward to the AHC finally making his apartment safe enough to go back to. This was like living in a giant dorm, which was not something Donald had enjoyed even during his college days. Though it wasn’t quite so bad now that he had a friend.

“Heaven save us if you’re actually needed to help lift,” Ren replied. “I guess I should get back to it. I’ve been feeling pretty confident in my own strength lately, but last night made me realize just how lacking I am. You burned a giant hole through that thing; I could barely leave scratches on it.”

“Whoa there. The *only* reason I lived long enough to get that shot off was because you were there to draw its attention,” Donald said. “Given how it was smashing through freaking everything it touched, I’d say it’s outright amazing that you were able to last like that.”

“Maybe so, but there’s still a long way for me to go.”

Donald didn’t have a good reply to that, because Ren was right. Both of them were only just starting out; it would probably take months, if not years, before they were even semi-competent superheroes. They might have different ways of doing it, but they each understood how important training was.

“When you finish at the gym, feel free to swing by,” Donald offered. “This can be a two-player game, you know.”

“Appreciate it, but...” Ren held up his hands, turning them carefully so his palms were facing Donald. “They only look human, remember? Not sure the claws are built to handle fragile electronics.”

“We had someone build a computer that fits on my forearm and runs more than twenty video games all at once,” Donald replied. “I bet they can create a controller that you’ll be able to use. I’ll tell them you’re my training partner. It’s a lot easier to level in these things when you have a friend.”

Ren hesitated then lowered his hands. “If you can get me the gear, I’ll play some games with you. But you have to agree to keep hitting the gym with me. Deal?”

“Deal.”

\* \* \*

In his chambers, Balaam was perusing a tome of ancient power, searching for a spell he could use to properly reheat an old stew without boiling it over, when he felt the familiar twinge of pain behind his right eye. With a heavy sigh, he shut the book, went to where his carefully concealed and padded box was stored, and removed the silver mirror. His hands rested against the smooth surface, dulling the pain that told him it was time to converse. A familiar voice entered his head.

*“Balaam, how go your preparations?”*

“As good as they can with no actual deadline to work with,” Balaam snapped. How were *his* preparations going? He wasn’t the one holding

things up, though even Balaam would admit that his task was the easier of the two.

*“That, I’m happy to say, is no longer good enough.”*

A trickle of excitement, tentative but undeniable, wormed through Balaam’s heart. Could it be? After all these years, were things finally progressing? He kept his voice stoic—even if no one but the mirror’s other holder could hear him, there was still a certain way evil wizards were supposed to act during these things.

“Are you saying that the time has come?”

*“I am saying it draws near. Very near. Within a week, perhaps two, I will finally have the last pieces we need. I have prepared my loyal ones as much as I can. A few days to bring them the rest of the way into the light and purge those who dissent and we will be ready to move.”*

Balaam resisted the urge, barely, to lift his hands off the mirror and clap with enthusiasm. With that timetable, it would be only two or three weeks until they could begin. Amid his excitement, he also felt fear slither its way in. For so long they’d been plotting. For so long it had been but a scheme that was more mad dream than tangible plan. Now that it was finally turning into reality, it was a bit scary. What they were about to do could never be undone.

“Very well. I’ll bring the ones I trust in and get them up to speed. There will only be a few of them, of course, but it should suffice for what’s needed on my end.”

*“A few will be plenty. Once the fuse is lit, others will be drawn in whether they like it or not. We only need enough to get things started. Move forward. I will tell you when things are ready on my end.”*

With that, the voice faded. Balaam slipped the mirror back into its box. He put it away and didn’t even glance at the tome of spells he’d been perusing earlier. Balaam now had far bigger concerns than reheated stew. There was much work to do, many contingencies to plan for, and so many pieces to put in motion. He’d done the vast majority of the groundwork already, but what remained was no small task.

All that aside, there was still one part of his job Balaam had no idea how he was going to pull off. Pseudonym as he was now posed very little threat to the plan. However, should the man be sufficiently motivated, there was always the chance that Fornax might once again raise his ferocious head and emerge from the weak shell of his current self. Should that occur, the entire plan could be thrown off course.

Balaam needed to find a way to deal with Ivan Gerhardt, and he needed to find it soon.

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## Chapter 51

The jingling of the bell overhead as Tori shoved the door open was both familiar and depressing. On one hand, it was nice to be back at Ridge City Grinders, and she was looking forward to checking in on Chloe. On the other hand, she was only here because Ivan had dropped her off while he parked the car, meaning she still had a full day of office work in front of her, followed by more guild training that night, and a few hours working on her meta-suit before she grabbed a quick nap to do the whole thing over again. The vacation was over, and now she had to go back to living her double life. At least field training would only last another week. And there was coffee, which was something to be grateful for.

Thankfully, the line was light for once, and Tori quickly made her way to the counter. To her surprise, Chloe's cheerful face wasn't there to greet her; Tori had been certain she'd seen the other woman's shock of white-blond hair when she stepped through the door. Seconds later, a soft tap fell on her shoulder, and she turned to find her favorite barista standing behind her with a pair of extra-large cups in hand.

"Morning!" Chloe said cheerfully. "If you've got the time, I took my break and thought we might catch up a little."

"Of course." Tori wasn't actually all that sure she did have the time, but there was bound to be a little residual sympathy in the office she could milk if the talk made her late. Besides, she'd accidentally drawn Chloe into a dangerous situation with robbers and a crazy meta. The very least she owed the woman was a morning chat.

Chloe led her through the store, past the clustered tables and toward a pair of soft purple chairs set up by a window. Tori couldn't be certain, but she felt pretty sure they hadn't been positioned so out of the way last time she'd been in the store. It had been a week, though; some other customers had probably screwed with the layout. As they arrived, Chloe passed Tori the cups and grabbed a small table barely wide enough to hold a laptop. She placed it between the chairs; Tori set both coffees down on top of it.

“Let’s start with the most important part,” Chloe said as she and Tori settled into their seats. “Are you okay? Doctors gave you a clean bill of health and everything?”

“Fit as a fiddle.” Tori raised her left arm and stretched it, flexing her fingers and making a fist. “No long-term damage; they even patched me up so well that I won’t have scars from the bullet wounds. What about you?”

“I didn’t need much treatment,” Chloe replied. “Though I’m glad that someone sprang for a meta with healing powers, otherwise the jaw stuff might have taken a while.”

“Yeah, in all the confusion, I didn’t get to ask what happened there. How did your face get so hurt in the fight?” Tori could vividly recall the bruised, disjointed angle of Chloe’s jawbone, almost impossible to picture now against her perfectly uninjured face.

“Oh, that. I sort of... I did that to myself.” Chloe broke eye contact as she quickly glanced around, making sure no one else was near enough to overhear them. “You guys needed a distraction, so I... well, I punched myself in the face a few times with a stapler until I felt my jaw break, then said my bark was worse than my bite. With a broken jaw, you have a really crappy bite, which was why my bark was so loud and scary.”

“Huh. Sort of seems like if you took that statement literally, it should have given you a shitty bark,” Tori pointed out.

“That occurred to me later on, but I guess my power works more on what’s meant than what’s said. After all, the sayings aren’t always literal. Or maybe my own intent matters. I’m still sort of figuring it all out.” Chloe paused to take a sip of her coffee, wincing slightly from the heat of the liquid. “That’s part of why I wanted to talk with you this morning.”

Tori felt a prickle of worry dance down her vertebrae. “Did you want me to give you Donald’s number or something? I’m sure you want to talk to another meta now that you know one.”

Chloe stared at her friend for a long moment, then sighed and set her cup back down on the table. “I was hoping it wouldn’t come to this, but I had a feeling it might. ***Liar, liar, pants on fire.***”



Her words echoed through their small space, and Tori immediately glanced down to see if her khakis were combusting. Mercifully, they were still fully intact. Then again, all her clothes were built to be able to shift forms with her, so there was no guarantee fire would harm her outfit. It would make a hell of a scene, though, and Ivan had a tendency to frown on those.

“When we were trapped in the break room, you threw coffee on one of the robbers to give Donald a distraction. The thing is, the pot you used was full of cold coffee left over from the night before. We both know it shouldn’t have hurt him, but he screamed like he was burning. Steam even came off it. Donald’s power wouldn’t have let him do that, and neither would mine. That only leaves you, Tori. You were the meta who heated up the coffee.”

Tori considered her words carefully. Chloe’s power was hard to predict and seemed to obey a set of laws unlike anything she’d encountered. Still, the effects always held true to the saying that Chloe used, so assuming she didn’t tell a direct lie, there was a good chance her pants wouldn’t suddenly ignite.

“That’s a pretty big assumption to make just from me throwing a pot of coffee at someone.”

“It is,” Chloe agreed. “But after I made it, everything else that happened began to make a lot more sense. The way you charged into the fight despite being a paper-pusher, how quickly you figured out ways to use my and Donald’s powers, even the determination you showed when you shot yourself in the arm. At the time, I took it as you being you, and while that’s probably still true, I think there’s more to it. Part of the reason you were able to do all those things is that you have a power of your own, and you’re accustomed to using it.”

“Well, it’s an interesting theory,” Tori said. “Let me ask you, though, if I say something is hypothetical, and it’s not true, does that count as a lie?”

“Not sure, but I doubt it,” Chloe told her. “Like I said before, intent seems to count. If you’re trying to tell a lie, that’s what will set it off.”

That made things even murkier, which was precisely what Tori had been trying to avoid. There was no way out of this without some sort of risk, though. Even if she got up and left, she'd more or less confirm Chloe's suspicions. Plus, there was no telling how long her weird curse would last. Better to see things through for now and find out where that led.

"Let's say, hypothetically, that your theory was right. That I was a meta with a power of my own. Why call me out like this? What are you hoping to get from me? If it's money, you're out of luck. The office job pays decent, but not enough to be worth blackmailing."

"Huh?" Chloe tilted her head in surprise then gave it a hearty shake. "Whoa, no, no, no. I don't want to blackmail you or anything. I want *help*. I want to stop guessing at how this power works and actually figure the damn thing out. I keep setting it off by accident if I don't watch what I say. If you're a meta, you're obviously not a new one like me and Donald. I just need someone to help get me through this until I've got a handle on this stupid ability."

"Oh." It occurred to Tori that perhaps she'd been spending a bit too much time around supervillains. While the morally corrupt might want to profit from Tori's secret, it made sense that Chloe would desire help above all else. She hadn't been taken in by the guild or the capes; she was just stuck with a power that didn't come with instructions, trying to muddle through her life while keeping that strange ability a secret. Tori had been lucky; she'd understood what happened to her and had the skills to control it. Heck, even Donald had it better; at least his power could only be activated under certain conditions. Chloe's could turn on at any time just by accidentally picking a poor turn of phrase.

"Okay, Chloe, let's assume I am a meta for a moment. What if my power is nothing like yours? I mean, yours is clearly rooted in magic. Maybe my hypothetical power came from a science mishap. Even if I wanted to help you—which I do—I'm probably one of the worst metas out there to do it."

"I'll take the worst over no one." Chloe fidgeted with the coffee cup clutched in her hands, staring down into its half-drunk contents. "I need to get this under control. It's fun, and it could be a really neat power in its own

right, but I have to figure out how to use it properly. Otherwise, it's just going to keep causing me trouble."

"Have..." Tori hesitated, unable to believe the words that were about to leave her mouth. "Have you considered going to the AHC? I'm pretty sure they have classes and training specifically for new metas. They're bound to have someone there who can help you." Much as it galled Tori to put another friend on the path to being a cape, Chloe needed help, and better she get it from the good guys than entangle herself with the guild.

"I thought about it, but I don't want to be a superhero. Honestly, I don't think I even can; my power just isn't that offensive," Chloe admitted. Tori was inclined to disagree, seeing as it had let her punch out a strength-based meta, but she said nothing as Chloe continued.

"Going to the AHC, it feels... dangerous. Like I'm putting myself in a world that I might not want to be in. Once I do that, there's no going back. They'll know who I am and what I can do, and if for some reason they ever decide I might be necessary as a tool, I might not have a choice. Meta drafts have happened before. That's why I don't want to get involved with some mysterious organization. I'm just asking someone I consider a friend if they'll lend me whatever help they can."

"Forcing me to tell the truth or burn was a bit heavy-handed," Tori pointed out.

"True, but my break is only so long, so this saved us both fifteen minutes of you trying to lie your way out of admitting what you are—what we *both* are. But you're right, I'm asking a lot. It's time I showed you some trust. ***A penny saved is a penny earned.***"

"How does that one work, exactly?" Tori didn't feel any different physically, though her mind was far more relaxed knowing that she wouldn't be in danger of having her trousers set aflame for one little fib.

"Every time I resist the urge to spend money, whatever I would have spent doubles," Chloe explained. "It only works with cash, though, and I have to be both genuinely tempted and able to buy it. No pretending I want a house, resisting, and watching my bank account swell. It just earns me a little extra grocery money here and there."

“Pretty useful,” Tori said. “So, look. I meant what I said about being the worst person to help you, but that doesn’t mean I won’t still try. That said, I do know a few other people who might be better suited to figure out how this ability of yours works. Are you okay with me sharing your secret? It would only be with people that I trust, I promise.”

Slowly, tentatively, Chloe nodded her head. “If you trust them and really think they can help, then I trust you. Let’s just not broadcast it all over town though, okay?”

“Don’t worry; I’ve only got one or two in mind. The first would be the best, but unfortunately, that one is also a super long shot. The second is like us: still inexperienced, but I have a feeling she’d definitely help out. One more thing, though. We won’t be able to start until next week. I’m sort of swamped every day and night until then.”

“That’s fine,” Chloe said, a relieved smile cresting her face. “Honestly, I wasn’t even expecting that much. It’ll give me time to try and figure out where we should start.”

Tori glanced at the clock and confirmed that she would indeed be stepping into the office late. So far, it was in the forgivable bounds, but she needed to hurry if she didn’t want to catch hell from Ivan, especially since she was about to try and con a huge favor out of him.

“I’ve got to head in,” Tori said, picking up her cup and rising from the chair. “But you’ve already got my number from when we set up the catering, so text me next week and we can work out the details. Just keep things vague, you know?”

“Nothing to worry about there,” Chloe replied. “I’m a big fan of keeping things private.”

“Figured as much.” Tori began to turn toward the door then stopped, facing Chloe once more. “Just out of curiosity, why go through all this to come to me? I mean, you know Donald too, and wouldn’t have had to strong-arm him into admitting he was a meta. I get not wanting to go to the AHC, but why not ask him for help?”

“I thought about it; I even picked up the phone to call you and get his number a few times. It’s just that... well, he’s a superhero now. He’s out there stopping crime. Just last Friday, he fought this giant monster in the middle of a club. I feel like he’s got better things to do than help out some untrained meta that doesn’t want to sign up with the heroes.”

It made a certain amount of sense; Tori could see where Chloe was coming from. But at the same time, this was Donald they were talking about. He’d have definitely made time for someone he thought needed help. At least, the Donald she’d made friends with would have, but that Donald wouldn’t have tried to take on a giant monster. His new job was clearly changing him.

She just hoped it wasn’t into someone she had to count as an enemy.

## Chapter 52

“Are you asking me for help or permission?” Ivan seemed unfazed by Tori’s rundown of her unexpected coffee discussion, taking it all in with a passive, almost bored expression. She’d expected him to at least be annoyed. Instead he kept clicking away on his computer as she spoke, no doubt clearing out the backed up emails from his week away.

“Um, both, I guess?” Tori was still taken aback by his disinterest in the issue at hand, but she steeled herself to press on, apathy be damned. “Let’s start with the help part. Is that something you’re willing to do?”

“Depends,” Ivan replied, eyes still trained on his monitor screen. “By ‘help,’ do you mean train a meta that owes no allegiance to our guild, or do you mean dispose of someone who knows about your secret? If it’s the former, then no. If it’s the latter, then still no, but I have some other people I can recommend for reasonable rates.”

“Oh, pretty please let that just be a terrible joke,” Tori said, unapologetically glaring at her teacher.

Ivan finally turned from his computer and set his hands heavily on the desk. “The guild does offer certain services like that, but no, I wasn’t serious about killing the barista just because she figured out you were a meta. I was, however, serious about not wanting to train her. As you might recall, I’m not big on students, especially ones I wouldn’t be educating in the guild’s code first.”

“Chloe isn’t asking to be turned into the next Lodestar; she just wants to get better control over her power.”

“You would be surprised how quickly ‘better control’ turns into ‘all the power,’” Ivan said. “If Chloe wants help from me, or someone with better qualifications, then she is welcome to enlist in the guild. Of course, as you well know, that is neither an easy nor safe path. However, as I have a vested interest in a meta not accidentally causing havoc or chaos in our city, I

have no objections to you helping her gain better control and understanding of her power.”

“Really?” Tori backed away slightly from the desk, accidentally betraying her shock. “I expected you to fight me a lot more on that.”

“Tori, you have one more week of field training and a single test remaining before you can become a full member of the guild. One of the things that will change at that point is the amount of hand-holding and supervision you receive from me. Your time is just that: yours. So long as you don’t violate the code, you’re free to spend it however you see fit. If you want to train this woman then I won’t stop you. But if she becomes a problem, then she becomes your problem... yours to fix or to be dragged down by. Understand?”

“Understood,” Tori replied. “But let’s go back to the thing about less hand-holding. Does that mean you’re not going to be my mentor anymore?”

“I will still be around in some capacities,” Ivan told her. “A mentor and student are always bonded, which is why so many guild members avoid taking them. But you will have gotten past the largest of the hurdles and proven yourself to be worthy of membership. From that point on, you alone will determine how you further your education.”

“Guess that means no more nightly quizzes of the code or you drilling me with hypothetical scenarios and seeing how I would deal with them.” She’d meant the words to sound playful, but to her surprise, they came out tinged with sadness. Her time with Ivan hadn’t necessarily been easy, and heaven knew she was tired of his endless emphasis on the code, but at the same time, it had gotten to be a comfortable, familiar routine.

Ivan coughed slightly into his hand, the first time he’d betrayed a sense of discomfort since she’d barged into his office. “To be frank, Tori, after you’ve become a full member of the guild, you won’t be residing with me anymore. This was an arrangement done only for the time in which you needed my guidance and supervision. You’ll be free to move into the guild headquarters or find a spot of your own.”

“I just can’t stay.” She wasn’t surprised, not really. In the back of her mind, Tori had always known that her garage apartment in the heart of

suburbia was a temporary arrangement. And at least she had a place to go—even if it was a place stocked full of criminals and weirdoes.

“Would you even want to?” Ivan asked. “I imagined this would be more akin to opening a cage than handing you an eviction. You’ll be free to go where you like and live in whatever way pleases you, which I imagine will involve a cluttered, messy lab with little more than two plates, a microwave, and a miniature television.”

“That’s a weirdly accurate description of my last few places,” Tori admitted.

“Don’t feel bad; I based the guess on Doctor Mechanical’s first apartment. Anyway, the point is, I’m not kicking you out the door as soon as your last trial is over. You’ll be free to apartment hunt and figure things out as you need to. While neither of us might have precisely wanted this arrangement, it’s not so bothersome that I can’t hang on for a little while longer.” Ivan smiled at her, betraying the fact that he’d actually just said something bordering on nice.

“Yeah, you’re not as bad as I expected. At least you can cook.” Tori decided it was best not to push her luck; after all, she’d gotten permission to help her friend and a kind word out of Ivan. Best to quit while she was still ahead. “All right, boss, time for me to head back to work. After a week away, there are a ridiculous number of meetings for me to schedule.”

“Oh, that reminds me, don’t make any plans for lunch,” Ivan told her. “The office is throwing us a surprise ‘welcome back’ party. My understanding is that they got Thai from that place three blocks over.”

“That’s really nice of them.” Tori found herself unexpectedly touched by the gesture, in spite of the fact that she’d seen how close the office was when they were taken hostage.

“The people here are good, decent folk,” Ivan said. “And they tend to look out for their colleagues. Which brings up another thing: have you seen Donald today?”

Tori shook her head; Donald had been stuck in meetings all morning. The rumors around the break room were that he was having his



project load assessed and reassigned in order to free him up in case the AHC had to call him in for an emergency. A lot of people thought it was the first step in getting him to stop coming in to the office. They speculated that after this he'd be given the "opportunity" to telecommute as much as he liked, and eventually, he'd likely get paid for doing nothing. Capes weren't exactly attacked in the street, but the non-guild criminals out there sometimes tried to hit them when they thought their guard was down. The bigger Donald's profile got, the more risk there was that someone would try to come after him while he was on Vendallia's clock.

"You may want to reach out to him and see how things are going. From what I understand, things have been a bit tough for him around here since he became a cape. A little friendship might go a long way."

"Nice as that sounds, you'll understand if I'm a little suspicious about why you want me to reach out to a superhero," Tori said. "Putting up with a friendship is one thing, but that borders on you encouraging it."

"Of course I encourage it." Ivan turned back to his computer, the rhythmic clacking of the keys resuming. "The continued existence of our guild is predicated on us being more trouble to fight than to tolerate. A few friendships across the moral lines only make us less tempting as targets."

"I guess that's true, even if it feels a bit manipulative." Tori regarded her teacher carefully as he punched away at the keyboard. "Does that mean you've got a few friends over at the AHC as well?"

"Don't be ridiculous. Who on earth in that organization would have wanted to befriend Fornax?"

"Well, Lodestar—"

"Lodestar reaches out to everyone she thinks she can help," Ivan said, cutting Tori off. "And it paid off in the form of us stopping Orion. She was the only one who saw recruiting me as a good idea, though. Trust me: Fornax has no friends at the Alliance of Heroic Champions, which is why it's all the more important that his apprentice keep the one she managed to make. You never know when you might need someone over there to speak on your behalf."

“Let’s hope it never comes to that.” Tori left the office, though her mind stayed with Ivan. Stoic as her teacher was, she’d been around him long enough to get a bit of a read on him. Something told her he wasn’t revealing the whole truth about having friends among the capes. It was something she’d dwell on later, when there was time.

For now, she still had a whole Monday to get through.

\* \* \*

It wasn’t until lunch—which was both delicious and heartwarming; the rest of the floor had gathered to wish her and Ivan a happy return—that Tori finally found herself free at the same time as Donald.

He emerged from a conference room with the telltale combination of weariness and relief that spoke of a long meeting that had finally come to an end. She hadn’t noticed in the chaos and surprise of the club, but he seemed different than Tori remembered him. Not physically—he was still a wiry young man with red hair and freckles—but the way he held himself had shifted. No longer did Donald Moss merely trudge through the hallways, visibly counting the minutes until he was free of their fluorescent-lit cage. Now he had an air of confidence about him. He moved like a man who knew his surroundings were temporary, and that something far greater awaited him on the outside.

Donald noticed Tori in her cube and smiled, giving her a nervous wave; suddenly the illusion vanished. But Tori knew what she’d seen. Donald was changing, bit by bit. And really, how could he not? He was a cape now. No one could take on a job like that and remain the same as they were before.

“Glad to see you’re all right,” she told him, standing up from her seat and giving him a brief, office-appropriate hug.

“That’s supposed to be my line,” Donald replied. “I was really worried you wouldn’t make it out of there, but I didn’t have your cell, so I couldn’t check in to make sure you and your friends were okay.”

“We all escaped fine, thanks to you and that other guy... Medley, I think the news said his name was?” Tori knew perfectly well what the other

cape's name had been. She also had a sneaking suspicion that in another form he resembled Ren, Donald's friend, but she had an image to keep up, even if it meant playing dumb.

"Yeah, he's another new guy at the AHC," Donald confirmed.

"He seems like a tough SOB. The news was showing surveillance footage and stuff people shot with their cameras, and it was an incredible fight. Weren't you scared, though? That thing seemed like a real monster." Tori didn't consider this part to be a lie—that rhino-creature had been flat out terrifying. She wasn't even sure how she would have fought it, at least without her meta-suit. But Donald had managed in spite of everything.

"Oh yeah, I was freaking out during the whole fight." Donald didn't seem at all embarrassed about his fear as he sat his laptop down on the cubicle desk and settled into his uncomfortable chair. "There were at least three times where I was a thousand percent sure I was going to die. Only Medley and way too much luck got me through it."

"You seemed so composed when you told us to leave." That part was total bullshit and they probably both knew it, but the guy had tried to put himself between innocent people and a monster. He deserved a little bit of flattery for that sort of bravery. "Didn't you even consider trying to run?"

"Honestly... it was the first thing that went through my mind." Donald's pale cheeks flushed slightly, and he busied himself with opening his laptop to avoid Tori's gaze. "Like I said, I was scared. All I could think of when that thing started coming after me was how to not die."

Tori settled back into her own chair but stayed far enough away from her desk that she could continue watching Donald as she spoke. "So, why didn't you? There's bound to be some gadget in your computer that would have let you get out of there." This was a question Tori had been burning to ask ever since Donald decided to stay behind in spite of being able to run. She didn't understand it, simply couldn't fathom why he'd lay down his life like that. Fighting for friends and family was one thing, but they could have evacuated with the rest of the club, and everyone would have probably been safe. Instead, Donald and Medley put their lives on the line to protect the retreat of strangers. The survivalist mentality Tori had spent half a lifetime honing simply couldn't square up with such actions.

“I mean... I wanted to, really badly. But if I had, then who would have stopped that creature?” The flush in Donald’s cheeks began to fade, and he managed to glance back over at Tori as he spoke. “Medley can take a beating, but he wasn’t able to hurt the monster very much. And sure, the AHC could have dispatched someone else, but there’s no way of knowing how many people would have been hurt by then. I just asked myself what the real superheroes would do, what Lodestar would have done, and then tried like hell to pretend I was one of them.”

“Donald, you stared down a monster with nothing but a computer pad and a weird tiger creature for backup. If that doesn’t make you a real superhero, I’m not sure what bar has to be crossed.”

“Maybe it will feel real once I save the world or something,” Donald replied. He pressed a few keys on his laptop and a screen full of e-mails appeared. “On the upside, looks like I’ll have a lot more time to train soon.”

Tori debated pretending to be in the dark, but Donald knew how gossip traveled in the office. Her acting unaware crossed the realm into unbelievable. “I heard they were transitioning off a lot of your projects?”

“If by ‘a lot’ you mean ‘pretty much everything’ then yeah, that’s what they’re doing,” Donald said, letting out a heavy sigh. “By the end of the month, it will be like I don’t even work here anymore. Which, I guess, is the point. At least I’ll still get a paycheck, though.”

“Wait, you get a paycheck and don’t have to show up to the office? Hot damn, someone sign me up for superpowers and monster-fighting,” Tori declared.

“It won’t be forever, at least not at my full rate.” Donald tapped another key and brought up a calendar for the rest of the year. “Basically, they can’t fire me for volunteering to protect innocent people, so they’re forcing me into early retirement. A few people at the AHC warned me that it might happen, but I thought they were just exaggerating.” Another few clicks and the calendar vanished, the digital reminder momentarily banished from sight if not mind.

“Looks like you’ll have to get used to another cubicle-mate.” Donald’s voice couldn’t have been any more bitter if his mouth had

suddenly turned into a lemon.

“We’ll see about that,” Tori replied. “My internship is up in a few weeks anyway. There’s no guarantee I’ll even be able to stay on here. It’s possible I might be gone long before you stop coming in.”

“Pretty sure Vendallia doesn’t want the PR hassle of firing an intern who was heavily injured in an attack on their offices,” Donald pointed out. “Besides, you do great work, and Mr. Gerhardt’s opinion carries a lot of weight around here. If he vouches for you, you’ll get hired. There’s nothing to worry about.”

“Maybe so, but I’m not one to count my chickens.” Tori reached over her desk to her purse and fished about for several seconds before finding what she was looking for. “And I’m also not one to take pointless chances. So, if either of us ends up leaving, let’s make sure we can still hang out when the mood strikes us. You said you didn’t have my cell number, right? Well, let’s fix that right here and now.”

Tori held up her phone and almost chuckled at the barely constrained joy on Donald’s face. Ivan had been right; a little reaching out did go a long way. Tori was surprised at how happy he was to have one friend that wanted to stay in touch after their office time ended.

Which just went to show that, smart as Tori was, she still had her blind spots.

## Chapter 53

With work done and Tori off to the guild for night training, Ivan was just settling in with a good book when his doorbell rang.

Moving carefully, power already flowing into him as he prepared for the possibility of an assault, Ivan peered through the peephole at the mysterious person on his doorstep. It was neither a salesman nor a neighbor as Ivan had half-suspected, but instead the gently smiling face of Wade Wyatt. Muttering curses, the vulgar kind rather than the magical sort, Ivan unlocked his door and pulled it open for the man who was both his best friend and the leader of their guild.

“To what do I owe this unexpected intrusion?”

“Certainly not a hospitality lesson, though it seems you could use one,” Wade replied, walking in without waiting to be invited.

“Looks who’s talking. You usually call before stopping over. In fact, you’re downright pathological about it.” Ivan’s annoyance turned to concern as he relocked his door. If Wade was stopping by without calling, it either meant there hadn’t been time to do so or he didn’t trust the phone and the visit was supposed to be secret, neither of which boded particularly well.

“Yes, well, something needs your attention, and I felt it was best to bring the matter before you personally,” Wade said. “You know that during every training session, we make a point of taking the apprentices to see a code-enforcement, correct?”

Ivan nodded. “It’s not pretty, but they need to know what happens to those who break our rules. And it’s a good way to show them what those sorts of jobs are like before they make the mistake of agreeing to take one.”

“Glad you approve, because I just got word that Onslaught is held up in Guatemala. Nothing too serious, but it’s unlikely he’ll make it back this week, and certainly not tonight, which is when the code-enforcement is supposed to take place.”

“Wade... you can’t be serious.” Ivan waited for the sudden burst of laughter or clapping to signal that it was a joke. Instead, his friend merely stared at him, no mirth to be seen. “You want me to do a job in front of other people? And kids at that?”

“None of them are children; they’re just younger than us,” Wade rebutted. “And anyone with a television screen has seen video of you fighting before.”

“Fighting, yes. Killing, no. Surely there’s someone else qualified to do this,” Ivan said.

Wade nodded, a short, sharp gesture that didn’t reassure Ivan in the slightest. “We have plenty who are qualified and some who are willing; however, the problem is one of seniority. When Balaam heard about Onslaught, he volunteered to handle the code-enforcement himself. As a councilor and a proven warrior, no one in the guild can say they are more capable of handling the task than he. No one save for our most powerful and renowned enforcer, of course.”

“Fucking Balaam.” Ivan sucked in a breath through his teeth, trying to smother the embers of rage that blazed at the bastard’s name. “You think he’s planning something?”

“It’s always possible,” Wade admitted. “Field training is dangerous in itself, code-enforcement even more so. It wouldn’t be the first time a trainee didn’t make it back, though those incidents are usually not the fault of the instructor.”

“Still, offing an apprentice seems like a stretch. He’s guaranteed to piss off their mentor and maybe a few other members as well,” Ivan pointed out.

“I’m not claiming Balaam plans to lead all of them to their death,” Wade said. “In truth, I have no idea what he’s got planned for the apprentices. Perhaps he wants nothing more than to teach a good lesson and make you worry in the process. It wouldn’t be out of character for him. All I know is that unless Pseudonym steps forward, Balaam is handling the code-enforcement. That seemed like the sort of thing you’d want to be made aware of.”

Ivan stood motionless for several seconds, weighing the risks of each possibility against the other. If he let Balaam go, there was a good chance he'd do nothing more than teach the lesson, meaning Ivan had been fearful over nothing. Of course, he might also seize the opportunity to eliminate, injure, or otherwise incapacitate his own apprentice's competition. Balaam was usually smart in his scheming, but with pride on the line, nothing was ever certain. On the other hand, if Ivan took over the job, he could make sure the rookies were safe the entire time. And all it would cost him is creating four more people who looked at him with nothing but fear in their eyes.

"Better scared than dead," Ivan mumbled, more to himself than to Wade. "Get me the information about the enforcement and have our recon people do some proper scouting. We're clear on the cape front, right?"

"This one is on the other side of the country, and we've set up the necessary decoy crimes to make sure you'll have all the time you need," Wade assured him.

"Then I guess there's nothing left to do but tell Balaam to fuck off and put on my costume." Ivan repressed a sigh and tried not to think about the fact that he'd only just gotten the blood out of it from the last time. This was the price he paid for freedom. For him and those he loved.

\* \* \*

Tori was dragging ass as she gathered with the other apprentices in the lounge. Her long day at work had stretched on forever and the brief catnap she'd grabbed in her guild bedroom had only served to make her more tired. Idly she wondered if this would be the sort of training that might lend itself to stopping by a gas station and picking up a half-dozen or so energy drinks. That thought went quickly out the window as a familiar—way too familiar, in fact—figure stepped into the lounge.

Ivan was in his full Pseudonym outfit; bland and nondescript as it was, the change still seemed to alter him. The stoic, detached demeanor remained, but instead of calm, he seemed to radiate the potential for violence. Just from looking at him she knew this wasn't Ivan showing up to a council meeting or walking around making introductions. He'd shown up to work, and she couldn't imagine the task before him was a peaceful one.



Behind him, Tunnel Vision waited just outside the room, their silhouettes outlined by the hallway's lighting.

"Apprentices," he said, his voice as stable as always, yet somehow harsher than Tori expected. "What is the most important, most sacred, most vital part of this guild?"

"The code." Tori answered without a second thought, and she noted that the others echoed her. While she doubted they'd gotten the same thorough training and speeches she had, it seemed their teachers had instructed them on how important the code was all the same. Or, at least, how important they had to pretend it was.

"That is correct. The code of this guild is our armor. It protects us, conceals us, allows us to live in the shadows. All around the world there are metas trying to get rich or seize power by their own means, and inevitably they must deal with the Alliance of Heroic Champions. Through the code, we stay below their radar, always out of reach, always too hard to chase. They know of us, yet because of the code, they are forced to tolerate us. The code ensures that we are smart, careful, and, above all, that we remain unseen. However, the code is not only armor, keeping those in this guild safe; it is also a sword used to carve out those who would bring trouble down upon our heads."

Ivan didn't pace, didn't move, didn't so much as flinch as he spoke. He was rigid, unmovable, a manifestation of the very code he loved so dearly. If they hadn't already known, no one in the room would have guessed that this controlled man was once the wild beast of destruction known as Fornax.

"For the most part, we leave other criminals undisturbed. The AHC needs them to prop up their image, and the last thing we want is to leave them scarce on villains to drag before the cameras. However, sometimes we get word of criminals going too far, seeking the sort of power that might threaten our very world—which troubles us as much as the capes—or committing the sort of crimes that work counter to our interests. The gang we're going after tonight has begun to cause our guild a lot of trouble. They've targeted assets owned by guild members, a crime we would punish regardless, but even worse, they've been buying up black market

information on the identities and loved ones of various capes. Can anyone tell me why that could negatively impact us?"

"An unhinged cape is an unpredictable cape," Lance said. He earned a few surprised stares, to which he gave a small shrug as if to say that even he paid attention from time to time.

"Simplistic, but true," Ivan agreed. "Logically, our organization is not worth the trouble of taking a run at. We cover our tracks and have great lawyers on retainer. But when a cape loses their family, when anger and grief overwhelm that logic we depend on, sometimes revenge against the people who stole their loved ones isn't enough. Often it will boil over, causing them to try and take down every villain they can, including the ones they know they should leave be. This is why our code forbids killing the friends and family of a cape, even accidentally, and it's why we discourage it to non-members whenever possible. In the case of the gang trying to steal from us and trying to stir up capes, our discouragement is going to be the active kind."

For the first time since he'd walked in the room, Ivan hesitated. It was subtle, almost imperceptible unless one had been living in his garage apartment for the past several weeks and gotten to know him very well. That moment of hesitation, more than anything else that had occurred so far, put Tori on edge.

"I don't mean to mince words and dance around the truth; that wouldn't do you any good with what's coming," Ivan said. "You need to know what's going to happen, and you need to mentally prepare for it as best you can. We're going to leave the guild tonight. Tunnel Vision will send us to the warehouse where the gang we're after is hiding out, and I'm going to kill them. All of them. They've been warned, they refused to back down, and so tonight, I'm being sent in for a code-enforcement. This is a nice way of saying I will end every life inside that building. And you're all going to be there to watch me."

"That seems unnecessarily brutal," Beverly said, the words clearly leaving her mouth before she had time to consider them.

"I don't entirely disagree with you, but this is a necessary part of your education," Ivan replied, unbothered by the outburst. "These people

have no association with our guild and that's why they were given a warning to back down. You, however, *are* part of the guild, and *this* is your warning. We cannot tolerate code-breakers here for many reasons, one of the most important of which is that it gives the capes a foothold to bring us down. If they can go after one of us, it could be the first step in allowing them to go after all of us. So we handle our problems in-house, before they ever get the chance to mount an investigation. No one here is above the code, not even your councilors. Better to show you what happens to those who don't heed that warning than let you become counted among them."

Slowly, Ivan met the eyes of every apprentice in the room. "These people were going to die no matter what, whether you watched it or not. None of their blood is on your hands, and unless you take a code-enforcement job from the board, it never will be. This is happening. Even if you tried, you couldn't stop me. Don't waste time feeling guilty. Instead, learn from what I'm showing you. If it keeps even one of you from forgetting how seriously this guild takes the code, then perhaps these lives won't be lost entirely in vain."

He turned back to Tunnel Vision, who were waiting patiently. "Whenever you two are ready, please open the door."

\* \* \*

The sudden onset of humidity took Tori by surprise, even though she should have expected a climate change. In the distance, she could make out bells ringing and the long low whistle of an unseen ship making its way across water. Tunnel Vision's doorway had let them out near a harbor, so close that, if she strained, Tori could make out the sounds of waves crashing against the piers. In front of them was a dirty brick building, the high windows on several sides broken out. Occasional bursts of light would come from within—flashlights sweeping through the surroundings. It was more familiar than Tori would have preferred, a reminder of the days when she holed up where she could and constantly stole to finance her projects. Places like this were ones she'd quickly learned to avoid. They were too convenient and tempting for gangs of actual criminals. Sooner or later, one would move in and Tori would be out a place to stay, along with any possessions she couldn't sneak away with.

In front of them, the air shimmered and Arcanicus stepped into view. It was somewhat reassuring to see their usual field teacher, though everyone couldn't help noticing his face was pinched and weary this evening. Wordlessly, he handed out the pendants that would keep them unseen then cast a new spell that created a softly glowing bubble around them.

"Near as I can tell, there are around twenty," Arcanicus said, speaking to Ivan instead of the apprentices. "At least seven are metas. The rest might be, but my wards didn't catch them. There's a pair of magic-users in there, so I had to be careful not to tip them off."

"That's fine, I prefer surprise above all else," Ivan assured him. "Are any more coming?"

"They've started their meeting so it's unlikely, but I can ward the place once you're in, just to be safe." Arcanicus shivered, though whether it was due to the chilly wet air or the events he knew were about to transpire was anyone's guess.

"A ward would be appreciated. Also, keep an eye on the apprentices. I should be able to handle that many, but my powers aren't well-built for protection. If one of them is in danger, teleport them out here to join you. Apprentices, do your best not to get in danger. You're almost guild members; I hope you can handle at least that much."

Ivan turned to face his charges, and Tori noticed that for the first time that night his eyes had changed. Once more they had become orbs of darkness lit only by glowing red runes. Those eyes, Fornax's eyes, meant things were about to get serious. Her nerves tensed, and she mentally moved herself a little closer to fire-form. She'd be damned if she had to get yanked to safety like a puppy wandering too close to a street.

"The most important rules for tonight are to stay silent, stay focused, and above all else, stay out of my way. Once we're inside, I won't be able to coddle you, so if anyone starts to lose it, take care of each other." He looked away from them, back at the warehouse filled with criminals who didn't know their time on the planet had almost run out.

“For what it’s worth, I’m sincerely sorry for what I’m about to make you watch. Feel free to hate me afterward; you’ll have every right. But do me a favor and try to keep yourselves from being this example for a future class of trainees. I take no more joy in doing this than you will in watching it.”

With that, Ivan headed toward the warehouse, and the apprentices followed.

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## Chapter 54

Unlike the crisp, humid air outside, the interior of the warehouse festered with must. It permeated everything around them, soaking the building in a depressing fog of neglect. Tori's ears perked to the sounds of chuckles, whispers, and the scuffing of boots. The gang was nearby, and for a moment she was surprised they hadn't bothered stationing a guard at the door. Then the others moved forward and she saw a man with a snake tattoo on his face lying on the ground, neck twisted at an inhuman angle. Ivan had killed the man upon entering, before he had a chance to sound an alarm, doing it so quickly that even the apprentices on his heels hadn't been fast enough to catch him in the act. Tori fought the urge to gulp audibly. She'd seen far worse than a bad man given a quick death in her time on the streets. And she knew she would see worse again before the night was done.

A few steps ahead of the huddled apprentices, a soft glow lit the room as the gathered flashlights threw off a cumulative shine. Standing on the edge of the shadows, still partially hidden by stacked boxes that no doubt contained drugs, guns, or some other illegal ware, Ivan turned back to look at his charges. He held up a single hand, signaling them to stay put, for the moment at least. The command given, he stepped out of the shadows. From the way the small noises of discussion died, Tori had no doubt they'd noticed him. No one had the chance to yell before Ivan spoke, and once he did, there was no need for questions.

"You all know why I'm here. You were warned and chose not to listen. Anyone who wishes for a quick death should lie down right now. That much mercy, I can still show."

There was some shouting and the sound of heavy footsteps. When Ivan next spoke, Tori was taken aback by the sadness in his voice.

"No takers? So be it. Apprentices, come out. It's time for you to see what happens to those who cross the guild."

Tori was the first to emerge from behind the boxes, and not by happenstance. She knew this wasn't easy for Ivan, the man who wanted to

do nothing more than live a normal life with his family in suburbia. He was doing it for the guild, for the peace he wanted to protect, and tonight, he was doing it especially for them. If Ivan was willing to work so hard to show them a lesson, then, as his apprentice, she owed it to him to learn as best she could. No matter how hard it was to watch.

Quick as Tori was, she still missed the first two kills. By the time she rounded the corner, there were a pair of corpses at Ivan's feet, both distinctly missing their heads. A massive meta bigger than Thuggernaut was rearing back to level a mighty punch at her teacher, while a man who looked like he'd been bred with a mosquito reared back to stab at Ivan with the three-foot blade poking out of his face. Several feet away, a woman was muttering under her breath, conjuring a strange black cloud in her hands. Tori's stomach briefly tightened with fear as she watched the three metas coordinate an attack on the man who had come to destroy them.

She needn't have spared the worry. Ivan grabbed the mosquito man without looking and threw him like a javelin into the chest of the woman with the cloud. This allowed the giant to take his swing, which Ivan stopped on impact, a small shield appearing over the spot where the meta had punched him. Ivan grabbed the man's arm and effortlessly lifted him overhead, then charged across the room to where the mosquito man was trying to free himself from his cohort's chest. Using the big meta as a club, Ivan rained three blows down on the entangled pair. When he was done, he'd not only finished them off, but also turned his weapon to pulp.

Gunshots rang out as the human members of the gang tried to do what dozens of capes couldn't—take down the monster once known as Fornax. Ivan dashed across the room, moving so quickly he seemed more blur than man, and dispatched the shooters as easily as if they were made from glass.

"Jesus." Beverly said the word more like a prayer than a curse, her dark skin several shades paler as she watched Ivan finish off the gunmen and leap up to a decrepit catwalk where a man with bladed tentacles attempted to rain down blows upon him. "He's... he's not even trying, is he?"

On the catwalk, Ivan had easily snagged one of the tentacles as it came in for a strike and yanked the attacker over to him. One punch and the man was down, blood streaming through the holes in the metal grating beneath his corpse. Another meta shimmered into view behind Ivan, raising a knife that looked like it belonged in a history book.

“Of course he isn’t,” Lance said. While he hadn’t gone pale, his usual cheeriness had vanished, leaving behind only a stalwart determination to keep watching. “That’s the man who helped kill the unkillable Orion, who nearly fought Lodestar to a standstill, whose power is on par with the greatest metas in history. And he, or someone like him, is who they’ll send after us if we fuck up.”

The blade slammed into Ivan’s back, only to bounce back and knock its wielder slightly off-balance. It was the only attack he got off. Ivan whirled around before the man could vanish again. Another blow and the blood streaming from the catwalk became a small waterfall.

“I get that he’s strong, but why do they need to show us this?” Beverly asked. “We know the code is important. We get the stakes. What’s the point of making us watch all this killing?”

Tori opened her mouth to try and explain. Before she could, to her surprise, Warren answered the question, and he did so better than she could have.

“Maybe *you* knew the stakes going in, but not every recruit would. This is an organization of criminals, many of whom have already fought capes and other metas on their own. Some would think the rules were flexible, or that they were strong enough to ignore them. This is about putting the fear in them, in us. They’re making sure we understand that if we fuck with the code or the guild, that’s what’s waiting for us.” Warren nodded to Ivan, who dropped from the catwalk onto the back of another gang member, the sound of breaking bones echoing as he landed.

Those criminals that remained started to panic. The lone man they’d expected to defeat was shredding through them at an alarming rate. Several turned to run, heading for the exit and the four trainees watching the slaughter. They made it only three steps before Ivan was there, standing in front of them. He didn’t bother taking his time; instead, he swept his hand



through the air in front of them. A red streak followed his movements, and as he reached the end of the line, the first man's torso began to slide forward, away from his legs.

Lance turned away, willpower momentarily broken. Tori could hear Beverly taking deep breaths, probably trying to fight back the urge to vomit. She didn't blame either of them; in fact, she was impressed they'd been able to hold it together for this long. The four corpses in eight pieces that Ivan had neatly created were only thirty feet away from them, bits of life still lingering in the top parts.

This time, Ivan paused before moving on, casting a quick look back at the apprentices who were dutifully watching his show. Whispering a few words, he set his hands on the ground. Moments later, all eight pieces burst into a brief, smoky black fire that burned out in seconds, leaving only ash.

"Corpse-fire? But that's a real spell," Warren mumbled, apparently surprised that Ivan's magic could do more than brute combat.

Tori was just thankful he'd gotten rid of the gory sight and allowed Lance and Beverly to regain some sense of composure. In a blink Ivan was gone again, zipping around the building, finishing off the few stragglers and those trying to hide. It was brutal, fierce, and bloody, but as she watched, Tori realized that Ivan seemed to make a point not to let anyone suffer. Every kill was efficient, every blow deadly. There was no pageantry, no joy in the task at hand. Ivan was simply getting it done, as quickly and safely as he could manage.

At last, the final gang member had been finished off via a punch to the torso that left a nearby wall splattered in red. Ivan made his way back over to the apprentices. Everyone was still standing, though Lance had needed to duck behind the boxes and vomit briefly while Ivan mopped up the stragglers. His dark eyes, burning with red runes, looked them up and down slowly, taking in their shaken expressions. Though it almost pained her to do so, Tori forced the corners of her mouth into a small, reassuring smile.

"I hate these jobs," Ivan said, somehow calm despite the blood and flesh clinging to his costume. "But I do them when they're needed because the guild is important to me, and that means it's something I want to

protect. You may think the way we handle things is too cruel, or gruesome, and that's certainly your right. However, the world before, without a guild or rules, was much worse. Hundreds of civilians could be caught up in the wake of some half-mad new meta's destruction; turf wars between meta gangs cost countless people their homes and lives."

He turned to look at the bloody scene he had created, unnatural eyes gazing through the building to a time long since passed. "If that were the case now, some of those countless civilians could be people we love. Even criminals have people they care about. I hate these jobs, but they keep the guild and the code safe, which in turn, keeps the people that I love safe. So I'll keep doing them when the need arises. You can hate that we do things like this. You probably should. Just understand that it's a necessary price to keep the order."

With that, Ivan walked past them through the warehouse's front door where Arcanicus and Tunnel Vision were waiting. After a few moments, the apprentices followed. Before leaving, each spent a moment to soak in the spectacle that had been created by the guild, *their* guild. Everyone took something different from the experience, but all walked out of the building changed.

Tori was the final apprentice to exit, and to her surprise, Ivan was still there, waiting for her. The others had stepped through Tunnel Vision's portal; she could see them back in the guild lounge as they waited for the window through space to close.

"You okay?" Tori asked, sidling up to her teacher as they moved toward the exit.

"You have a bad habit of stealing other people's lines," Ivan replied. Part of Tori relaxed at the snippiness in his voice. The Ivan in that building wouldn't have bothered being snarky. It was good to know her real mentor was still in there under all the blood and bluster.

"Obviously, I'm fine," Tori replied. "I spent years as a thief and a street rat; I've seen plenty of shit. You, on the other hand, just had to go on a killing spree. Can't imagine that's sitting too well."

“Not my first, won’t be my last,” Ivan told her. “But audiences always make it worse.”

“That part I can see.” Tori glanced back at the warehouse as she and Ivan drew near to the portal, recalling all the bloody corpses they’d left inside. “Is Arcanicus going to do cleanup? I’m guessing we don’t want people stumbling on that grisly scene.”

“Actually, that’s exactly what we want,” Ivan said. “He laid down wards to keep us from leaving any incriminating evidence behind, but killing the gang is only half the job. People knew they were taking on the guild, which is part of why they bumped up on our radar. Now they’ll serve as a warning to anyone else who might get similar ideas.”

“Efficient, but sweet damn that seems cold,” Tori muttered. “Wait, how can other people know about the guild? I’d never heard of you until I joined. I assumed we were all top secret.”

“Oh? You never heard rumors about a shadowy criminal organization that skirted the capes’ attention while pulling off grand, elaborate scores?” Ivan momentarily paused just outside the portal that would bring them home. For whatever reason, sound didn’t travel through spatial tears, so it was the last chance they’d have for private conversation before the night was done.

“Well, sure, but those were just... stupid... rumors... wow, you all are crafty sons of bitches. Making yourself into a crazy conspiracy so no one will believe it when they catch sight of the real thing. That would be like... like if Bigfoot released the shitty fake Bigfoot footages just to throw people off.”

“That’s my smart apprentice,” Ivan said. “We keep the actual truths hidden. All most people know is that there’s a gang with no patience and no mercy, and that if you get a warning from them, you should heed it. Some have learned about us—no secret is perfect—but we keep things obscured enough that the majority are never sure what’s true and what’s not. All they know is that if they break our rules, bad things happen.”

“Like I said: crafty sons of bitches.” Tori shook her head and forced out a chuckle. Neither of them really wanted to make small talk within sight

of the warehouse that Ivan had painted with corpses, but they both knew it was important. They needed to convince each other that Tori seeing that side of Ivan hadn't changed things, whether it was true or not.

"Come on; after a quick debrief, we're going to call it a night for training," Ivan said, motioning to the portal. "That means you might be able to squeeze in a whole four hours of sleep between work and your meta-suit."

"What can I say? I'm determined to keep the local coffee shop in business, even if I have to do it by myself." Despite her words, Tori had a feeling she'd be skipping the lab tonight. Even without the sleep deprivation, she felt more drained than she had in a very long time.

She just hoped that when she finally did close her eyes, she'd be able to see something other than the inside of that blood-soaked warehouse.

## Chapter 55

“Do you have a moment?”

Apollo looked up from his desk, unsurprised to find that Lady Shade had entered his office without bothering to use the door. From less dedicated personnel he'd have considered it impertinent, but Lady Shade had long ago shown herself to be the sort who valued efficiency over propriety. It was a quirk he tolerated because she was loyal, and that trait mattered more to him than any others she might possess.

“For you, always.” Apollo closed his laptop as he spoke, sealing off his work from prying eyes. Trust was well and good, but discretion had rewards all its own.

“You wanted to be kept abreast of any incidents of mass killings among meta-human criminals,” Lady Shade said, cutting right to business in the way that Apollo liked. “We just got word from Seattle that a gang was wiped out in a very bloody manner sometime last night.”

From the shadows that swirled about her body, Lady Shade produced crime scene photos of a warehouse interior strewn with corpses. She set them down on his desk, and waited as Apollo perused the contents of each one.

“No doubt about it, this is that cursed guild's handiwork,” Apollo said at last, setting down the photos. “You can always tell; the actual kills are clean, but the bodies are left messy. They want to send a message to the people who find the bodies more than the people they killed.”

“Our informants say the gang in question had gotten a warning that they angered someone higher up the food chain and that they ignored it,” Lady Shade reported. “No one knows many details, but every low-level scumbag in the area seems to be minding their manners today. Everyone's scared they might step on the wrong toes and be next. Some of them even think we're the ones who pulled this hit.”

“Well, in a way, they aren’t wrong.” Apollo’s smile dimmed when he looked back down at the bloody pictures, as did his glow. “By tolerating the existence of these people, we’re at least partially culpable for their actions. ‘All that is needed for evil to flourish is for good men to do nothing,’ as the saying goes.”

“We can’t be everywhere, and from all accounts, these people were real bags of shit,” Lady Shade assured him. “You’re the one who tells the new recruits that even superheroes can’t save everyone. We’ve just got to do our best and take solace in the victories we manage.”

“As always, you’re quite right,” Apollo said, artfully skimming over the fact that he was technically agreeing with himself. “And I intend to make sure these people’s deaths do not go to waste. Tell me, were you wondering how I knew there would be an incident like this coming?”

“I assumed you had sources,” Lady Shade admitted.

“If only. I’d give much to have information from within that guild. No, I knew it was coming because we spotted their trainees out last week. Over time, I’ve noticed that when there’s a confluence and we both get new members, inevitably there will be a slaughter of morally repugnant criminals some months into their training. No doubt it’s meant to teach their recruits how to deal with external threats. I assumed that if they were out in the real world, that point had to be drawing near, which is why I put you on alert.”

“Very impressive,” Lady Shade said. “But, if I may, how does that help us? Shouldn’t we have tried to catch them in the act?”

“Certainly not.” Apollo shook his head, curly golden locks tumbling as he did. “These kills are professional-grade, clearly handled by the more powerful, experienced members. Going after one of them blindly would just cost us people, and it’s likely they’d still get away. No, what I’m looking for is what comes after the killing. Without fail, once one of these clean jobs pops up, within two weeks’ time we find a crime scene that’s almost, but not quite, at guild standards. Still clean and tidy, but always with a few telltale errors that we don’t see on the usual jobs.”

“I get it; you think they make the kiddies go out on a job all of their own,” Lady Shade concluded. “And that’s what you’re aiming for.”

“Precisely.” Apollo reached into his desk and pulled out a pad of paper. He scribbled across the yellow surface. “Contact these people in the AHC and let them know I need a quiet alert raised. We don’t want to tip our hand, but it’s crucial that we be ready when the opportunity to squash their newest crop arises. With a few carefully chosen allies on watch, I believe we can manage. Oh, and have Cyber Geek and Medley stop by after you’ve talked to everyone. I’ll want to let them know that as of this weekend they’ll be spending a few weeks on standby as part of their training.”

“Don’t you need more than just those two? I mean, the guild has four recruits,” Lady Shade pointed out.

“I’ll likely grab a third or so from the pool after I see how everyone is improving. But those two have a bright future, and I want to help them seize it.” Apollo finished his writing and tore the page off the pad, handing it to Lady Shade.

“Cornea, the Crystal Baller, Optimize, and Stalwart Iron. I’ll get to all of them within fifteen minutes and have the newbies headed to you in thirty,” Lady Shade promised. She grew murky and indistinct, then vanished seconds later as she slithered out the wall through a nearby shadow.

Once she was gone, Apollo reopened his laptop and got back to work. He’d need to pick some backup for his rising stars, just to make sure everything went smoothly. There were plenty of prospects who were workable—metas with either power or charisma instead of a combination of the two. Normally, they were destined to live and die on the mid-list of popularity charts, known but not remembered. If he was lucky, however, they might get swept up in the wake of Medley and Cyber Geek’s good PR. Nothing wrong with getting some bonus press for the AHC’s newest rookies. That was assuming things went perfectly, of course, which would require good fortune and better planning.

Thankfully, the guild was sticking to their usual timetable, which made it all the easier to predict their moves. If things went to plan, they’d

soon haul in four potential villains, unmasking them in front of the cameras and cementing the new recruits' status as capable superheroes.

It would make for a wonderful appetizer, something to tide him over until the main course arrived.

\* \* \*

While his size was useful for leverage, intimidation, and reaching things off the high shelves, the radioactive protein bar that had changed a scrawny nineteen-year-old into the powerful Thuggernaut had also made dealing with anything delicate an act of constant effort. Thankfully, Doctor Mechaniacal had the materials and know-how to ease things for the muscular man, which was why Thuggernaut was able to peruse his books on a specially reinforced e-reader. He was sprawled out on a couch also custom made for members of the guild who had more mass than standard springs were meant to bear when Johnny ambled into the lounge.

"Thought I'd find you here." The smaller man adjusted his suit jacket before leaping over the edge of the sofa, coming down on the far end, just out of range of Thuggernaut's pillar-like legs. "You always like to read after the rough stuff. How's the kid holding up?"

Thuggernaut didn't bother trying to fight the inevitable; he and Johnny had been friends for years, and when Johnny Three Dicks decided there would be a conversation, then sooner or later there would be. He clicked a bookmark function on the reader and set it down on a nearby coffee table.

"If by 'the kid,' you mean my apprentice, she's doing as well as can be expected. Monday's lesson was especially hard for her; she never had criminal inclinations before getting her powers. That was the first time she ever understood the darker side of the guild she was trying to join. Honestly, that woman has more makings of a cape than one of us. If she didn't hate the AHC so much, it would have been a good fit."

"You did the best you could to make sure she knew what she was signing up for before she joined," Johnny said. "Can't make the right choices for them. Plus, given how strong she's getting, I'm sort of glad she decided to stay on Team Villain."



“She would have been a handful, no doubt about that.” In spite of his worries about his apprentice and her future in the guild, Thuggernaut couldn’t quite resist the grin of pride that inched its way across his face. Beverly was growing by leaps and bounds; he had no doubt that one day she’d be far stronger than he. If she’d been won over by the capes, within a decade she’d have been as big a nuisance as Apollo.

“Yeah, but giant terrifying dragon works better on our side anyway,” Johnny pointed out. “And Beverly’s a tough nut. She’ll get past Monday. Or she’ll start drinking it away like many before her have. Either way, have some faith. The kid will find peace.”

“You’re probably right. At least she didn’t have to go through it alone. I wasn’t part of a confluence, so I got to sit through that show solo.”

Johnny let out a long, three-note whistle. “Who taught you?”

“Morgana.” Thuggernaut shuddered involuntarily. “The whole thing lasted less than a minute, which was all the more disturbing when I realized she could have ended it in seconds.”

“Count yourself lucky. I had to watch Arcanicus do the job,” Johnny replied. “Do you know what the smell of fresh gore mixed with the scent of a reanimated horde is like? Let me tell you, no one makes an air freshener strong enough to cover that up.”

Thuggernaut had been in an enclosed room with Arcanicus’s skeletons more than once; he could only imagine how the stink multiplied when murder was added to the equation. Morgana’s display had been mercifully short on smell and sound. Her victims had almost no time to react, and those who did manage a few seconds didn’t waste their time screaming. A few *had* tried begging, not that it helped.

“Anyway, we bounced back after that, and so will all the rookies, Beverly included,” Johnny continued. “From what I hear, Pseudonym went out of his way to take it easy on them. Even got rid of the gorier stuff if it was too close.”

“It’s certainly better than Balaam would have done,” Thuggernaut agreed. “Pseudonym at least has a vested interest in not seeing any of the

apprentices break, especially this close to their membership trial.”

“Speaking of, that’s why I stopped by.” Johnny reached into his pocket and pulled out a slip of paper with half-illegible chicken scratch scrawled across it. “Just got word from up top. I’m on distraction duty for the night they do their job.”

“You’re not going to be around to watch Beverly’s trial?” Thuggernaut jerked forward, a motion that others might have taken as threatening and subsequently fled from. Johnny, thankfully, knew his friend better than that. Thuggernaut only got violent when the situation called for it. Of course, when it did, he got *really* violent, which was part of why he’d ended up lumped in with the criminals in the first place.

“Nope, and neither are you, technically. Looks like you and the other mentors are getting sequestered to watch the show, at least according to Doctor Mechaniacal.” He held out the note, which Thuggernaut gingerly took from his much smaller hand. “You can read it for yourself, but the long and short is that Doctor Mechaniacal thinks you might be tempted to intervene if they turn the whole thing into a colossal fuck-up. Only the people strictly necessary will be around to oversee things. Everyone else is either on house-arrest at the guild or on distraction duty to make sure we keep the capes off their backs.”

Thuggernaut managed to make out every third word or so on the note, which seemed to corroborate Johnny’s report. Much as he didn’t like it, Thuggernaut couldn’t exactly protest the logic of the order. The truth was that if his apprentice were in trouble, he probably would try to jump in and help, even if it messed things up in the long run. There was no way he could just stand by and let his student get hurt if he were there to stop it, which was obviously the precise reason that he wasn’t going to be there.

“Do you need to pull a big one, or can it just be noisy?” Thuggernaut asked as he lowered the note. “I don’t entirely trust you to put together something elaborate on this short of notice.”

Johnny snorted. “Well, we both know I’m not going to do anything that requires that much work, so it looks like simple and noisy will have to do. I’m leaning toward fire at the moment. There’re a few abandoned blocks in various cities all over the country that I keep notes on for just such

an occasion. Allot an hour to clear out anyone squatting in them and I can whip up a grand distraction with minimal fuss.”

“I know how well you keep track of things, so I’ll be personally scouting the locations to make sure they’re still abandoned,” Thuggernaut replied. In the field, Johnny was as solid and dependable as they came. When it came to prep work, on the other hand... well, he wasn’t one to put up with the tedious when there was excitement to be had.

“All these years and still no trust. It’s hurtful, that’s what it is.”

“Do you actually want to do the work of rechecking all the locations and finding the one that best fits your needs?” Thuggernaut asked.

“Oh holy shit no. That’s all you, big guy.” Johnny hopped up from the couch and slid around it, already angling for the door. “I’ve got better things to do. Cocktails to drink, hearts to break, standard dapper villain stuff.”

“Have fun at happy hour,” Thuggernaut called. Once Johnny was gone, he scooped up his e-reader and continued his book. Though there was no real reason to and nothing in the conversation he could point at as a cause, Thuggernaut nonetheless felt much better than he had before Johnny’s interruption. Somehow, he always managed to take a person’s mind off the things that were bothering them, even if only for a while. It was no doubt part of why Johnny always got called on for distraction duty.

If anyone knew how to divert people’s attention, it was the villain known as Johnny Three Dicks.

## Chapter 56

After the hellish, bloody night that was Monday, the rest of Tori's week flew by. Work, field training, and a few hours building the meta-suit followed by an amount of sleep most would only classify as a nap, and then the whole thing repeated itself. Fortunately, life as a criminal and scientist had prepared her for pulling long strings of all-nighters one after another. This was not to say that she wasn't significantly dragging by the time the weekend rolled around. In normal circumstances, or as normal as her life ever got, Tori would have let something slip to the backburner in an attempt to get more rest. But work and training were mandatory, which only left her meta-suit, and that was the one thing she was absolutely not going to give ground on.

Thanks to the lab Doctor Mechanical had built below Ivan's house plus a combination of her paychecks and winnings from the desert trial, Tori's meta-suit was at last beginning to take shape. She'd built prototypes before, testing concepts and functionality on various bits at a time, but this was the first time she'd ever had the time, security, and funds to actually get one that might work when fully assembled. It wasn't quite there yet—she'd still need a little more time for that—but Tori was certain that she could have it up and ready to go by the night they had to pull their first job.

Well, she hoped as much, anyway. All they'd been told was that they'd pull a job at the end of field training. She assumed, or rather hoped, that meant they'd be given time to plan and coordinate on their own, which would in turn be more time to finish her suit. If there was one thing she knew about the guild, though, it was that one had to prepare for the unexpected.

This point proved itself for the umpteenth time as Tori, clad in her apprentice costume, arrived in the rookie lounge to find Ivan already there, dressed up as Pseudonym. He might have mentioned he was coming, or at least given her a ride instead of sending her off in one of the guild's automated cars after work. For a moment, her stomach twisted in fear as she wondered if there was going to be another demonstration like Monday's.

She soon realized that Balaam, Thuggernaut, and Arachno Bro were also gathered. Clearly, this had something to do with all of the apprentices. Once that was cleared up, she was free to be amazed by the fact that Ivan and Balaam were in the same room without arguing. That was no doubt helped by having the other two villains positioned directly between them.

Beverly had beaten her to the lounge, so Tori fell in line silently beside her friend. No one was talking, and while that might just mean a conversation had recently died, she wasn't going to be the one to break etiquette if silence was expected. Ivan had reminded her time and again that while he might be on her side, not everyone was. Especially the dickbag spellcaster with red irises.

Lance and Warren both wandered into the room in their own time, saw the spread of people awaiting them, and lined up with the other apprentices. Though Tori was expecting things to start when the last of them, Lance, arrived, the entire room remained silent. She was just edging up to ask what the hell was going on when the distinctive sound of moving metal caught her ear. Moments later, Doctor Mechanical arrived, decked out in his full meta-suit glory. It was strange: outside of the time he'd greeted her and the guild meeting, Tori had only ever seen Doctor Mechanical in full armor or none at all. Part of her wondered why those times had been different, but she was quickly distracted as the guild's leader began to speak.

"Tonight, on what is to be the tenth and final night of your field training, we have gathered you here to give you information regarding your final trial for admittance to this guild. Soon you will receive the details of your test, both what is expected of you and what resources you will receive. After that, you will have time to begin planning how to tackle your task. However, before we can get to the last test, there is another matter that requires our attention. Each of you lacks an important item you will require when it is time for you to work on behalf of this guild."

Tori had a hunch where this was going. The sly smile on Arachno Bro's face, or at least the arrangement of mandibles she took to be a smile, told her that she was on the right track. That was the reason their mentors had come. This was something important, something they were supposed to bear witness to.

“I speak, of course, about code names,” Doctor Mechanical continued. “You can’t very well use each other’s real names in the field, and referring to everyone as ‘Apprentice’ is a recipe for confusion. Our code names are, in many ways, relics of the life we used to have or the paths we were kept from going down. Ideally, your name will be known only within the guild, as the best jobs we do are the ones where no one knows we were there. However, life is not ideal, and therefore the code name should be something that conceals your mundane name and speaks to the true identity that lurks behind all of your masks. You were all warned that the time to choose was approaching, so I assume each of you has a name prepared.”

He didn’t phrase it like a question, and Tori couldn’t imagine that was accidental. Idly, she wondered if this was a test to see if they would complete a task even when not given a firm timeframe. It was possible—sometimes it seemed like everything they faced was a test, while other days she was certain the councilors were just making it up as they went along. It didn’t matter either way, though. She’d chosen her name earlier that week in a bit of inspiration that struck her as she was sleepily treading down to Ivan’s basement.

“Apprentice of Balaam, step forward,” Doctor Mechanical ordered. Warren obeyed immediately, eyes darting between his teacher and the man in a metal suit, uncertain of where his attention was supposed to go. “Apprentice, have you chosen a code name to wear as a member of this guild?”

“Yes, sir.” Warren didn’t stammer but only just. “If it pleases the guild, I would like to go by the name of Glyph.”

Doctor Mechanical paused then nodded his head. “That name is not spoken for, so you are free to claim it as your own. From here until your admittance or failure, you shall be known as Glyph.”

Relief was evident on Warren’s face as he fell back in line. Next up was Lance, whom Doctor Mechanical called out with an identical order and question.

“Pest Control, if it’s available.” Lance spoke with the confidence of a man who knew damn well his name wasn’t spoken for and didn’t seem the least bit surprised when the iconic helmet dipped into a nod once more.

Tori was glad he'd thought of something; she knew he'd been having trouble picking a good one. Plus, it sort of fit; bugs were considered pests and Lance was able to command them.

After Lance was Beverly, who stuck to her guns and chose Bahamut to the surprise of exactly no one that knew her. This only left Tori, either by chance or design, as the final apprentice to claim a name of her own.

"Apprentice of Pseudonym, step forward." Tori obeyed, glancing at Ivan and barely resisting the urge to give him a 'how crazy is all this shit?' wink. "Apprentice, have you chosen a code name to wear as a member of this guild?"

"I have. From this night on, I would like to go by Hephaestus," she announced, perhaps with a small hint of pride in her voice. She'd been pretty proud of that name when it came to her; it felt so appropriate. After all, she crafted stuff, dealt heavily with fire, and even had her lab in a basement. It was a good fit on all levels and betrayed nothing about her identity.

Which was why it was all the more disconcerting when Doctor Mechanial failed to nod, instead letting out a long, low "Hmmmm" from the depths of his throat. "The AHC already had a cape registered as Hephaestus. It looks like he's deceased now, but he had a sidekick that took on the mantle after he passed. One moment."

Although he appeared to be just standing there, the guild leader was evidently accessing some sort of name database and checking on availability. Tori felt her palms start to sweat and had to double check to make sure she wasn't leaking nervous heat. After hitting on such a good code name, it hadn't occurred to her to pick a backup. Shit... what was another good one? Socket? Sprocket? Hot Sprocket? Oh god, that sounded like a shitty porno or garbage microwave food. Wait, weren't sprockets from *The Jetsons* in the first place? Maybe the guild didn't care about copyrights, in which case—

Her slow descent into the maw of madness was mercifully interrupted as Doctor Mechanial spoke once again. "It looks like he took the title Red Hephaestus to honor his predecessor but still set himself apart.

The first Hephaestus didn't do much, but it was a name already worn by a cape, so if you'd like to reconsider, that's up to you."

"But I can still use it, right?" The pride in her voice had been replaced with fear verging on desperation as she scraped her mind for a replacement in case he said no. Unfortunately, all her worried brain could manage to think about was the goddamned *Jetsons*.

In what she would later consider to be the most beautiful show of apathy Tori had ever seen, Doctor Mechanial shrugged those metal shoulders and said, "If you want. Greek mythology is public domain anyway, so as long as no one is using it, then it's all yours."

"I'll take it!" Tori fought down the blush that started to rise in her cheeks and focused on composing herself in spite of the stares and slight snickers she was getting. "I mean, if it's available, then the name I choose is still Hephaestus."

"Then from here until your admittance or failure, you shall be known as Hephaestus," Doctor Mechanial announced. "And with that, all apprentices have chosen their names. How long you can wear them for is up to you to determine, though we certainly wish you the best of luck. Now, on to your actual trial."

From a compartment on his wrist, Doctor Mechanial pulled out a small device and set it down on the coffee table next to a half-drunk soda. Moments later, an image flickered into existence above it, glowing green text displayed on a black background.

"Starting tomorrow, you will be given access to Sanctum so that you may learn how to coordinate and plan a guild job all on your own. But Sanctum is a place for execution, not discussion, which is why tonight, you will review the parameters of your trial and decide how you would like to approach it. I should mention that you are not obligated to work together; though, if you split up, the resources will be divided proportionally. As you can see on the image, you have one week from tonight to complete your trial. Use your time well, for it is not your ally."

With that, Doctor Mechanial turned to leave, their teachers following a few steps behind him. Arachno Bro reached out to pound a fist



with Lance, now technically Pest Control, as he left, and Thuggernaut gave the newly named Bahamut a thumbs-up. Tori wasn't expecting anything from Ivan—he tended to keep a tighter lid than normal on his feelings when he wore that costume—so she was nearly bowled over when he placed a hand on her shoulder as he walked by, even going so far as to stop momentarily.

“Hephaestus, huh? I like it. It's a good name for you. People will respect it.”

“Hard to do worse than Fornax,” she whispered.

“Please don't remind me. That's why we let the new members pick their own names in the first place, to avoid incidents like that.”

Then he was gone. Tori watched him leave, the weight of his hand still heavy on her shoulder. In terms of training, he'd probably given the least out of any of the mentors in the room, but she still couldn't help feeling like he'd prepared her better than the rest of the apprentices. He'd taught her how to blend in, how to keep the code, how to survive. The others might have been taught how to become better criminals, but Ivan had educated her on the art of surviving in a villain's world. Even if he hadn't wanted one, Ivan had still done his best to turn his apprentice into a full guild member. Now it was on her to prove that she could go the rest of the way.

Turning from the door back to the glowing image in front of her, Tori found that the others were already clustered around it, and the looks on their faces were far from promising. They weren't as pale or sickly as when they'd finished Monday's lesson, but the expressions were closer to that than she would have preferred.

“Okay, you all seem like you just had to force down rotten cabbage, so what kind of damage are we looking at here?”

“See for yourself,” Beverly said, jostling Lance over to make room as Tori slid in beside her. The glowing green text was arranged simply, separated into the categories of Requirements, Resources, and Assets. The first one detailed what was expected of them, the second provided them with a budget and some basic gear they'd have access to, and the final

category was a list of ways they could spend their budget. Warren reached his hand forward and pressed his fingers to the bottom area. With a quick motion, he scrolled through the Assets sections, showing the variety of options available to them while the other two categories remained unmoving. It was more fascinating than helpful, as most of the Assets listed were more than double their meager budget.

Tori leaned over to look the document up and down, carefully reading each piece of information in Requirements and Resources no fewer than three times until she was certain there hadn't been any sort of mistake. Once she was done, she calmly stood back up and faced the rest of her apprentices.

“Well, since it looks like we're all about to fucking die, anyone else want to have a last drink with me?”

## Chapter 57

“You don’t think you might have been a little too hard on them?” Ivan asked, helping himself to another helping of gumbo from the impeccable spread that was set before them. After watching their apprentices choose code names, the mentors had headed off to a small celebration with food and drinks. Wade was already waiting for them, sans suit, a heaping helping of fried chicken on a plate in front of him. Almost no one knew how he ran the remote suit so seamlessly, and those that did were smart enough to keep the leader’s secret just that.

“This is meant to test them, see how they’ll deal with hard problems and still adhere to the code. If I gave them an easy one, it wouldn’t show us what we need to see,” Wade countered. He, Ivan, and Thuggernaut were the last ones remaining in the room, unless one counted Arachno Bro, who’d passed out in a pile of empty beer cans and cocktail glasses. Balaam had excused himself only a few moments after the party began. It was a bit rude, but given that he’d gotten through a whole evening without snapping at Ivan, no one was going to call him out on ditching. The night had been a peaceful one so far; there was no reason to go messing things up.

“Still, those were some heavy requirements,” Thuggernaut added. He had half a bottle of whiskey in a special glass that Wade had provided. Supposedly it was made of a crystal strong enough to withstand point-blank gunshots. All Thuggernaut knew was that it didn’t break when he picked it up, so that was enough for him. “The security level alone would be problematic for a rookie.”

“A rookie, certainly, but we don’t have one, we’ve got four. Four very bright, cunning, powerful metas,” Wade replied. “If they put their collective talents and minds together, I have no doubt they’ll be able to pull something off. Challenges are made to be risen to.”

“Let’s just hope none of them are crazy enough to try and do it on their own.” Ivan was already halfway through this bowl of shrimp, rice, and roux, with an eye on the pot that indicated it wouldn’t be his last.

“Normally that might be a concern, but after their ordeal in the desert, I think it’s safe to say that at least three of them understand the importance of teamwork,” Wade said. “And I daresay even Glyph will put aside his independent streak for a trial as important as this one.”

“Guess all we can do is hope.” Thuggernaut took a hearty gulp from his glass, the smooth liquor burning gently as it moved into his stomach. “We gave them the floaties and the lessons, now we hurl them into the pool and hope they can swim.”

“True,” Ivan agreed. “I just wish so many before them hadn’t reached this point and then drowned. I would be... unhappy, to see Tor—Hephaestus come so far only to lose herself now.”

Thuggernaut nodded, staring down into the depths of his drink in its special-made crystal. How many recruits had he heard about who fell apart when the stakes were real or got greedy and overreached in an attempt to pull off some spectacular score? How many would-be guild members reached this point and then went no further, all the potential they might have had snuffed out by an inability to adhere to the code? He’d been saddened by the news each time, but it was always a distant pain, nothing that cut him deep. Now he was forced to imagine how it would feel if Beverly, Bahamut, the young woman he’d worked so hard to help train, was suddenly gone from the world.

“You know,” Thuggernaut said, eyes still glued to the swirling depths of his drink. “I think I’m starting to see why taking apprentices fell out of style.”

\* \* \*

“Okay, let’s take this one piece at a time. Lance, break down the requirements for us.” Tori paced around the lounge while Beverly and Warren sat at the table near the vending machines, pens and paper stretched out before them. Only Lance remained near the projector, staring into the glowing words that seemed specifically designed to doom them.

“First off, we have until next Friday to complete the trial, but we have to give the guild a full twenty-four hours’ notice before we do it so they can make arrangements,” Lance said, reading the first point dutifully.

“Not a lot of time, but at least they didn’t only give us tonight,” Beverly muttered.

“Second, the job we pull must adhere to the guild’s code, meaning we have to minimize our chances of getting caught or causing civilian injury and avoid alerting the capes at all costs,” Lance continued.

“Yeah, yeah, that one was already a given.” Tori twirled her hands to indicate that he should get on with it.

“Third, whatever job we do must make a profit of no less than half a million dollars. No destruction for the sake of destruction or anything along those lines. We’re all on the same page, though; robbery is our best bet, right?” Lance glanced up from the projector to concur with his fellow apprentices, who all nodded.

“Any sort of kidnapping or extortion is probably going to get too complex,” Warren said. “Robbery is a quick, one-shot deal. Heck, we could knock it out this weekend if it weren’t for the next part.”

“Ah, you mean number four: we must defeat the security of a system rated at least Level Three or higher,” Lance said, turning back to the projector. “These include federal banks, the offices of higher-up government agencies, national museums, and the offices of most companies on the Fortune 500 list.”

“That’s the first real hurdle,” Tori agreed. “Level Three is nothing to joke about. When I was... well, before the guild, let’s just say I avoided them whenever possible. On top of being high-tech and frequently monitored, most have a hard-wired line to the AHC. It’s a service they pay quite a premium for. If we set the system off, the capes will come running.”

“Which means we have to steal at least five hundred grand from a place specifically designed to stop people like us from doing just that,” Beverly surmised. She glanced up from the paper, inspiration twinkling in her eyes. “Hey, wait, can’t Tori just hack some bank for us to grab the cash? As long as it’s one with a Level Three security system, that still counts, right?”

“First off, while I appreciate the vote of confidence, and I do know my way around a few programs, I’m more the buildy type of geek than the hacky one,” Tori replied. “Plus, even if I could manage it, that still wouldn’t work. Remember number five?”

“All team members must contribute to the job in some meaningful way,” Lance helpfully supplied. “I guess they added that because if hacking options were on the table, Tori could have split off from us and done it on her own.”

“Fuck a whole wet mess of that. I might have my prideful moments, but not even I’m cocky enough to think I could pull this off by myself.” Tori halted her pacing for a few moments, rubbing her temples as she tried to think of some way to get everything required for the task before them. “Keep going, Lance, there’s only a few left.”

“The sixth one is pretty straightforward: no evidence linking the crime to the guild may be left behind,” Lance said. “Obvious, but I guess they wanted to remind us to be careful. The seventh, on the other hand, seems to have been added just for evil kicks. If any member of a team is captured by either the police or the AHC, the entire team will have failed.”

“I think it was less evil than it was mischievous,” Beverly said. “That one is there to tempt us to split off on our own. After all, if we only have to be accountable for ourselves, then we don’t have to worry about being dragged down by someone else’s failure.”

“Is that how you took it?” Warren looked across the table with a touch of surprise, one of the first times anyone had ever seen genuine emotion on his pinched face. “I assumed it was there to ensure that teams actually worked together. If the failure of one means the failure of all, no one will sabotage a fellow apprentice who might have become a future rival.”

Silence fell over the room as everyone’s eyes gravitated to Warren. What he said wasn’t wrong; in fact, it was so spot on that they immediately believed he’d hit the nail straight on the head. It was, however, a bit disconcerting, both because whoever made the trial had accounted for the possibility of betrayal, and because only one of them had even seen it as a

possibility. It seemed Warren had been getting a somewhat different, possibly more useful education than the rest of the apprentices.

“Guess that means we’ll have to look out for each other, no matter what,” Tori said at last, breaking the spell of quiet that had inadvertently been cast. “Lance, what do we have in the way of resources?”

“Beverly copied down the whole list, but for the most part, it’s just standard gear: flashlights, rope, backpacks, lock picks... basically a ‘My First Crime’ starter kit. Aside from that, we have four thousand dollars to spend on whatever assets we want to purchase.”

“Which is obviously the part of our resources that really matters,” Beverly added.

“I’m not totally sure about that, but it’s definitely the part that requires action,” Warren said. “We have to figure out what assets best suit our needs, but before that, we have to determine what those needs will be by picking a target.”

“Actually, I disagree with you there.” Lance was still at the projector, scrolling through the large list of assets available for purchase. “There are a lot of options, but I’m starting to think they’re mostly here to trip us up. The vast majority of these are either very niche services or way out of our price range, but there are two that we can just barely afford. Round trip transportation by Tunnel Vision will run us thirty-eight hundred dollars, or we can rent those pendants from Arcanicus for a grand a pop. I doubt those prices, or the amount of money we have, is a coincidence.”

“Lance makes a good point,” Tori agreed. “Either the rates were lowered or our amount of cash was specifically picked to make those affordable. It gives us a choice of ways to lessen our risk. We can have magic that lets us slip around more easily, or we can get out of Ridge City—and by extension the AHC’s backyard—which makes us less likely to hit their radar.”

“What a coincidence. Both of those are tools we’ve seen and used multiple times, making us intimately familiar with their workings and limitations.” Beverly shook her head as she scrawled new notes on the

paper, scratching out previous writing with grand strokes of her pen. “These people really do think ten steps ahead.”

“It’s not like we’re the first apprentices they’ve made go through this trial,” Lance pointed out.

“And on the upside, this gives us a place to actually start.” Tori’s mind was whirling. Now that they knew the first decision to make, the task before her seemed less daunting. It was just a series of smaller steps, like building a new invention: take care of one manageable piece after another until something truly extraordinary had been created. “We need to pick cloaking or teleportation, and to do that, we have to decide what the best target for us to take on is. If we find a good one outside Ridge City, we go there, and if we see one ripe for the picking here, we grab the necklaces.”

Tori walked over to the table and tore a sheet of paper from Beverly’s pad. “Let’s divide and conquer. Lance, you check out any museums that have both Level Three security systems and the kind of exhibits that will get us to five hundred grand. Try to keep the focus on paintings and jewels. Pottery is too bulky and delicate, and sculptures are just a pain in the ass. Also, make sure we can easily clear eight hundred thousand, since art requires a fence and the guild might take the fees for that out of our profits.”

“Damn, I didn’t even think about that,” Lance said, joining the rest of the group clustered around Tori.

“Think of it like criminal taxes: there’s always someone taking a little off the top. Next up, Beverly, we need you to go through any banks that fit our security needs. Keep an eye out for ones that have a lot of safety deposit boxes or store precious metals. Cash will do in a pinch, but it’s bulky and comes with serial numbers that can be traced, so it’s usually more trouble than it’s worth.”

“I get the strong feeling that you’ve done this before,” Beverly remarked, flashing her friend a knowing grin.

“Never on this scale, but I’ve had to make off with ill-gotten gains on a couple of occasions.” Tori tapped Beverly’s pen and looked at Warren, who was waiting patiently for his orders. “This one is going to be a bit



tougher, but Warren, can you do some digging in to any well-secured branches of government agencies that have recently made big busts? Maybe raided a cartel's compound or something. Drugs and cash are out, but pretty much anyone who does crime for a living keeps a stash of something untraceable they can turn into money when the need arises. If the feds found something like that in their bust, we might be able to take it off their hands."

"That's not going to be easy information to find," Warren cautioned.

"I know, and if you come up empty-handed, it's okay. But as you're the only one of us with a more versatile power, I thought you might be able to pull some magic that no one else here could." Tori also secretly considered this avenue to be the most unlikely to pay off, which was why she handed it to the person in the room she trusted the least. With the rules as they stood, she doubted Warren would go out of his way to sink them, and he certainly didn't seem to harbor as much animosity as his mentor, but there was no sense in taking needless risks. Besides, he really did have access to magic, so maybe he could manage to uncover something useful.

"What does that leave you with?" Lance asked.

"My old stomping ground: corporate espionage," Tori replied. "I'm going to research every company that's developing experimental prototypes or working on tech under juicy government contracts. Grab one of those, sell it to a competitor, and we can easily clear the half a million mark."

"Well, if you've successfully robbed these places before, that sounds like our best bet," Beverly said.

"'Successfully' might be stretching it a bit." Tori's pen slowed as an unexpected wave of bashfulness overtook her. "I mean, I've robbed companies before, but I did say I avoided ones with Level Three security."

"Have you ever successfully beaten a system that strong?" Lance leaned in a little, as curious as he was pleased by the unexpected change in Tori's demeanor.

"Well... sort of. There was only one time I ever tried to rob someone with security that good, and to be fair, I did manage to make it all the way

inside their vault,” Tori said.

“And then what happened?” Beverly’s smirk said more than her actual words would ever need to. Friend or no, it was a rare chance to actually see Tori squirm.

“Oh, you know, not much. Found out the team I’d been working with was nothing but plants, realized the whole thing was a trap, got threatened with death, and then Doctor Mechanical came out and offered me a spot in the guild.”

“Wait... you tried to rob *the guild*?” Whatever Beverly had been expecting, that wasn’t it. Her eyes widened and her voice raised several octaves.

“No!” Tori quickly protested. “I mean, not directly. I tried to rob a company owned by the guild. And hey, I got pretty far, even with a team of betrayers. Plus, guild security is way higher than Level Three, so if anything, I’m over-prepared for this job.”

“That would be much more reassuring if you hadn’t walked directly into a trap last time you tried a theft of this caliber,” Warren pointed out.

“Yeah, well, last time I had a shitty team. I’ve learned my lesson since then.” Tori ripped the sheet of paper off the pad and folded it neatly before tucking it in her pocket. “All right, everybody, get researching. You heard Doctor Mechanical; starting tomorrow we get access to Sanctum. Let’s show them what we’ve got by walking in with a game plan.”

While the group didn’t exactly cheer with enthusiasm, there was a glint of determination in every eye present. It wouldn’t be easy, and it probably wouldn’t be fun, but they were starting to think they could do this. Tori knew too well how important that was. With enough guts and willpower, they may just be able to pull off a win.

Or, at the very least, they would go out trying like hell.

## Chapter 58

With the kids at Janet's and Tori undergoing training, Ivan pulled his car up to an empty house after leaving the guild. Eventually the party had wound down, with Wade heading off to his room and Thuggernaut hauling Arachno Bro off to sleep it off somewhere more comfortable. In spite of himself, Ivan chuckled at the memory of the large man trying to find a comfortable grip on the unconscious body with too many limbs. He'd forgotten how much entertainment could be had simply from hanging around the guild. No, that wasn't true; he'd forced himself to lose those memories. Thinking about it, staying around, it only made keeping himself detached all the harder. He was only still there to protect the guild and the peace. Ivan was only keeping a promise, nothing more.

When he turned on his living room lights and found an unexpected intruder standing there waiting for him, Ivan didn't jump in surprise. In fact, he showed no reaction at all, save for the glowing red runes that lit his eyes' suddenly dark expanse. Calmly, he turned and closed his front door, locking it and resealing the wards that had, not surprisingly, failed to keep the uninvited guest out of his home. Ivan didn't think of it as a failing on his part, though. Even the most powerful holding cells had only ever managed to contain Nexus for a few hours.

"And what the hell brings you here today?" Ivan had never fought Nexus before; the odd man with the kaleidoscope eyes generally preferred to deal with Quorum or Stasis, though few were aware of what made them such tempting targets. That was the problem with Nexus: his motivations were entirely his own, often incomprehensible to anyone else.

"Just checking in. Are you Fornax, the nothing, or the new one yet?" Nexus scratched his head, flakes of what appeared to be ash tumbling down to Ivan's nice clean carpet. "It's been a crazy week, and I'm trying to get my bearings."

"I'm not Fornax, and I have no idea what you mean by the other two things. My current name is Pseudonym, if that helps." There were few

things Ivan hated more than someone barging into his home, but any conflict with Nexus would almost certainly sweep up the rest of the neighborhood in collateral damage. That meant goodbye to his civilian identity, to say nothing of the lives of everyone with homes around him. Talking with this madman, bothersome as it was, would cost nothing more than his time.

He hoped.

“That’s the nothing, then,” Nexus replied. “And your girl, she’s not dead here, so did she take a name yet?”

“Just tonight. Tori is now known as Hephaestus.”

“Only tonight? Excellent, I’ve got plenty of time then. Or at least, I should. Never know quite what to expect over here. I mean, the fight is coming. That happens almost everywhere. But it will be interesting to see where the bits and pieces fall in the aftermath.” Nexus looked back at Ivan, almost as if he were registering for the first time that the homeowner was in the room with him. “Ah! Which is why I wanted to come talk to you. Your time as the nothing is drawing to a close, or should be. If, when—whichever—that happens, I’d be very much interested in seeing a fight between the new one and Quorum. Never got the chance to set that up when you were Fornax, but I think it would make for quite an interesting show.”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about,” Ivan repeated. “However, I do know that I’m not going to try and fight a cape, let alone one of the AHC’s leaders. Leaving aside the fact that it would do irreparable damage to the peace between superheroes and the guild, I’ve got no problems with Quorum.”

“But it was never about problems, was it? It was about power, testing it, gaining it, learning how to wield more of that monster inside you. Quorum is a strong one, you know. The fight you two could have, why, it might shake the very stars from the heavens.” Nexus winked a Technicolor eye and Ivan felt his already strained patience begin to thin.

“The stars are fine where they are. I’m not that man anymore. Now, if you’re done proposing ludicrous ideas, I’ll thank you to get the hell out of

my house.” Ivan fought to keep his voice calm, pushing down the violence that a too-familiar voice was beckoning him to unleash.

“Do as you will; that much always stays constant with you. But whether you fight Quorum or not, the stars will likely fall soon. Not every time, though. And in this one, things always seem to take their own turns. Still, it would make for a good show, and I’d even go so far as to say I’d be indebted to you for putting it on.”

“Sorry, no dice. Go watch it in some other dimension. One version of me is bound to have less self-control,” Ivan said. Nexus’s powers and the existence of multiple universes weren’t exactly secret—the man had never been shy about dropping hints that even the dumbest of people could string together. Unfortunately, travel between them was a highly experimental science among even the brightest minds. No one had a clue how Nexus did what he did, which made him all the more impossible to stop.

“Oh, would that I could! There are so many of you with so much violence in your hearts, but I’m afraid it’s impossible. Bringing in a ringer would chance too much, and I won’t spoil the whole show for the sake of a single episode.” Nexus shook his head, genuine sadness etched on his mercurial expression.

“Then make the me there fight the Quorum there. I don’t care how you get your kicks.”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” Nexus replied, head jerking up like a hawk who’d heard the rustle of a mouse in the brush. “In all the multiverse, there is only one Quorum. That’s what makes him interesting, you know. The rest of you? So predictable, the same motions even if the gestures change. But Quorum, he is truly unpredictable. That’s why I can’t go ruining things by cheating. Think over my offer, though, I’m a good man to be owed a favor by.”

Then Nexus was across the room, standing only a few feet from Ivan. He braced for an attack, but Nexus merely leaned in and whispered softly into his ear, words barely louder than the strum of a spider’s thread.

“Especially for a man who seeks to keep the stars from falling.”

As the words faded, Ivan realized he was alone in his home. Moving slowly, he pulled out his cell phone and pulled up a number on the screen. He stared at the green “Call” button for over a minute before putting the phone away. Nexus was cryptic and insane all the time, and even if he did know much, what he said wasn’t always true. No reason to wake her at this hour with some groundless prediction. Ivan wouldn’t let things come to that.

He would keep his promise, no matter what.

\* \* \*

The explosion engulfed not only his target but the ones on either side of it as well, catching them in flickering magical fire that quickly turned the wooden figures into cinders. Balaam bit his lip in frustration at the unintended casualties. Normally, he took pleasure in his power and how far reaching it was, but this training was about precision. After having to spend a whole evening holding his tongue around Ivan, Balaam’s annoyance and frustration were at dangerous levels. He needed to regain his composure, for the sake of safety, if nothing else.

Casting spells was more than just spitting out words and making gestures. It was about tapping into the primal current of magic that lived in their world. His body and mind acted as a conduit for that power, drawing it out and shaping it to his will. If he lost his focus or allowed his emotions to run wild, then the spells would show it. That was why his simple blast of attack-magic kept wiping out half the targets in the shooting range he’d booked. His burning desire to fight with Ivan was amplifying the more destructive properties of his magic. It was a facet of wielding the arcane that Balaam was well acquainted with and considered highly useful in certain situations, but this was not one of them.

The time for dealing with Ivan would come soon enough; he had to keep control until then. Knowing that the end was drawing nigh made it hard to stay composed, though. With the finish line in sight, Balaam wanted to just sprint ahead to cross it. But that would be folly. He’d long ago learned that he couldn’t act alone. All he could do was ready himself. Prepare. Because in a few weeks, when the man on the other end of the mirror put his plan into action, Balaam intended to enjoy every minute of it.

That was then, however, and this was now. Taking a deep breath, Balaam chose a new target and whispered a few words. This time, only the wooden dummy he'd selected exploded in flames, burning away to nothingness in a span of seconds. Balaam watched, the wicked smile on his face framed by the dancing shadows of firelight. He could hold it together for a little longer, play the part for a few more weeks.

Because when the day finally came and he was freed from his facade, Balaam would never again have to pretend to be some kenneled dog. He would be free, and the world would tremble at the sound of his name.

\* \* \*

“Had a feeling you wouldn't be sleeping.”

Ren glanced up from the weight bench to find Donald standing in the doorway to the gym. Despite the late hour, there were still a few others dotted throughout the giant area, working in their exercise when time permitted. Still, it was nothing compared to the plethora of sculpted bodies—some by powers and some by effort—that filled the room during normal hours. Only the most devoted, poorly scheduled, or sleep-deprived capes would come work out so deep in the night.

“I don't sleep much, anyway,” Ren replied, finishing his set of deadlifts and resting the bar carefully down on the rack. “Side effect of whatever made me into... me. Only need a couple of hours a night.”

“That so? Damn, now there's an ability I could get some use out of. I have to keep my late hours the old-fashioned way: energy drinks and poor health.” Donald walked over, idly picking up one of the smallest free-weights and moving it from hand to hand. “I've always been a night owl, though. Of course, back then, it was so I could squeeze in as much gaming as possible, for fun. Now I'm gaming to get myself up to snuff. At least it gives me something to do, since there's no way I was going to sleep tonight anyway.”

Ren contemplated lying back down for another set but thought better of it. Even as adaptive as his muscles were, they could still only grow so quickly. The truth of the matter was that he'd hit his limit for daily

progress hours ago; since then, he'd been working out to avoid dwelling on the same thing that was no doubt keeping Donald awake.

"Everyone goes on standby status sooner or later," Ren said, grabbing a towel and wiping down the bench. He didn't actually sweat, at least not measurably, but some habits were more about consideration for others than effectiveness. "That's how we have superheroes ready to respond when people need us. It's part of the job. And Apollo said he'd keep us at the bottom of the list, only sending us out if everyone else is already busy."

"I know. It was inevitable. I guess I just thought there would be more time, more training before we were suddenly chunked out into the world with people counting on us. I mean... if we screw up, someone could die." Donald set the weight down; his motion hadn't been doing much in the way of working him out in the first place.

"So far, you've tangled with a gang of thieves and a giant monster in a club," Ren pointed out. "If that doesn't get you ready, I'm not sure what will."

"Yeah, but I had help both times," Donald reminded him.

"And you'll have it this time, too. We're signed up as a pair; whatever call comes in gets us both as responders. As long as we've got each other's backs, we'll find a way to muddle through. Training is nice, but there's no better way to learn than by doing." Ren paused, momentarily thinking over Donald's last comment. "Hang on, I helped with the club monster, but I thought you were solo for the thing at your office?"

"Oh, yeah... I mean, I was." The tips of Donald's pale ears began to practically glow red, and he quickly looked away from Ren's gaze. "I was the only meta, but there were still other people who helped. You know, made distractions, that sort of thing."

"Uh huh." His toweling done, Ren threw the dry piece of cloth over his shoulder and took a long look at Donald. "Look, I know you well enough to know that you're not the type to try and hog glory, so if you're skipping over someone else's contributions to that fight, then I trust there's a good reason for it. That said, not everyone knows you as well as I do, so



you might want to work on your poker face in case they catch you off guard again.”

Donald jerked his head up, quickly scanning the gym to see if anyone was paying attention to them. As was to be expected of those working out after midnight, everyone was dedicated to their own efforts, oblivious or apathetic to the discussions of others. “Ren, can I trust you with a secret?”

“Seeing as you trust me with your life in the field, I’d say a secret is actually a step down,” he replied.

“I guess that’s a good point.” Donald looked around once more then leaned in to whisper. “I wasn’t really the only meta there. I had help, a lot of it, from a woman with a weird verbal power. I hate pretending I did it all alone, but she doesn’t want anyone to know that she’s a meta, so I told them I did everything.”

That more or less aligned with what Ren would have guessed occurred. Donald was the honest sort, but he also wasn’t the type to publicly out someone trying to live a normal life while meta. “Was it that girl we met last week? The one from your office out with her support group?”

“Tori?” Donald let out a small laugh and shook his head. “No; I think if she was a meta, she’d be tougher than all of us. Even without a power, she stepped up and kicked ass during the hostage situation. I mean, she had help since the other woman was using her powers on her, but still. It was really impressive; I wish I could have told people about it. Anyway, Tori is human. The one with the powers doesn’t even work in our office, she was just there by coincidence.”

“Lucky coincidence,” Ren said. “Well, don’t worry; your secret, and hers, is safe with me. Being a meta isn’t always easy, even if you’re lucky enough to be able to hide it. Honestly, I think if I’d gotten a different power, one like yours, I would have gone right back to my old life. I’d have spent the rest of my days on the sidelines, not trying to be a superhero.”

“You’re wrong.” Donald picked his weight back up and walked over to the rack, setting it down in its designated spot. “Maybe you wouldn’t

have gone all in like you have, but you'd have ended up here sooner or later, Ren. As soon as you got power, this was inevitable."

"How do you figure?"

"Because you saw a giant monster appear out of nowhere, and before you knew I had a way to shoot it, you raced off to fight the thing. No worry, no hesitation, no nothing." Donald sat down on the bench beside his friend. "Anyone with instincts like that isn't going to stay on the sidelines. As soon as you saw someone in need, that would have been it. Like it or not, you were born to be a superhero."

"Guess we'll see over the next few weeks," Ren said, purposely skimming past the rest of what Donald had said. Much as he appreciated it, Ren had no idea how to respond to something so heartfelt. So instead, he fell back on a tactic as tried and true as the punch: Ren changed the subject. "Speaking of, did you figure out what you're going to do about work? Can you go to the office and be on standby?"

"I think the AHC is going to submit some sort of request for time off on my behalf, sort of like if I got jury duty," Donald said. "I've got no doubt Vendallia will approve it; they've more or less been trying to get me out the door since they found out I signed on with the capes."

"That's a bummer," Ren said. "I know you got a thrill out of seeing that coworker of yours, Tori."

"She's just a friend," Donald replied, words coming out fast and reflexively.

"Yeah, I saw that for myself. But I wasn't talking about what she is, I was talking about how you feel. You've obviously got a thing for her." Ren's statement was not an accusation but rather a simple observation.

"I might, but I don't think she feels the same way," Donald admitted.

"Give it time. These things grow as you learn more about each other. Plus, you're a superhero now. Who isn't impressed by that?"

“Surprisingly, her,” Donald said. “She and Mr. Gerhardt are the only people in the office who haven’t acted like being a meta or signing up with the AHC is any big deal. If not for them, I doubt I would have made it through another week at that place. Guess it will be my last one for a while.”

“Maybe you’ll see her again elsewhere,” Ren suggested.

“No maybe about it.” Donald reached into his pocket and pulled out his cell phone. “On Monday, we exchanged numbers. As soon as my standby duty is done, I’m calling her up and asking her to get coffee.” His face, already pale, lost a few more shades. “Oh crap, I’m going to have to ask her out if I want to see her again, aren’t I?”

Ren put a reassuring arm over his friend’s back and patted him on the shoulder. “On the plus side, now fighting criminals doesn’t seem so scary, does it?”

## Chapter 59

When Saturday morning arrived, four bleary-eyed apprentices rode the elevator down through the guild's subterranean defenses and walked through the biometric screening hallway before finally entering the guild's most well-defended enclosure: Sanctum.

Tori, who had lost track of how much coffee she'd ingested as the night dragged on, had hit the strange, almost-high state that occurred during the second wind of sleep deprivation. Nonetheless, it was more than just a flailing brain's release of chemicals that had plastered a smile on her face as she watched the doors slowly part. It had taken all night, and there was still tons of work left to do, but they'd come up with a plan. Maybe it wasn't a great plan, but it was something. That alone was enough to give her hope.

None of the apprentices were terribly surprised to find Sanctum almost empty. Doctor Mechanical had emphasized that it wasn't a place people were supposed to hang out, and besides, most criminals preferred to work under the cover of darkness, making them functionally nocturnal. In fact, there was only one person in Sanctum, sitting back in a chair with a well-thumbed book in her hand.

At the sound of the door, Stasis jumped up from her chair, trying to look like she hadn't been caught completely off guard. Once her eyes settled on the four rookies making their way in, she let out a noise somewhere between a snort and a laugh. "What the hell are you four already doing here?"

"Doctor Mechanical said this was when we could enter Sanctum," Lance explained.

"Yeah, as in, you couldn't come in until now. That didn't mean you had to... oh shit, did you think this was some sort of deadline?" Stasis didn't bother waiting for an answer. She tipped back her head and let out a resounding cackle. "You have to be kidding me. Guys, this was just the first time you'd be allowed in, to make sure you didn't try and come down before you had things in order. No one actually tries to register their first

job after only a night of planning. I was put down here mostly as a formality, and because I don't sleep."

Doctor Mechanical's words, which had seemed so clear at the time, echoed through their heads. Yes, he'd said they couldn't come in until Saturday morning, and yes, he'd emphasized the need to spend their evening planning. But Stasis was right: at no point had he ever told them they needed to be down here after only a night to get things going. In fact, the only time limit they'd been given was that they had a week to finish the trial. Aside from that, they'd been free to work how they wanted.

"Oh, son of a bitch," Warren muttered, tipping back his weary, aching head. Unlike Tori, he was not accustomed to pulling all-nighters, and the strain of it had left him with the beginnings of what would ultimately be a splitting migraine.

"Maybe they'll think it's impressive," Beverly ventured. "You know, that we were willing to work so hard and set a new submission record."

"No one cares about your submission. All we look at are results," Stasis said. She folded the corner of a page in her book, closed it, and set it down on the chair where she'd been resting. "But what the hell, you're already here, so let's go ahead and knock this out. I'm supposed to show you how to work the board, though since Doc designed it, the interface is pretty fluid. Everyone come watch."

Stasis walked a few feet over to one of several stations set up throughout the room and touched a screen. It lit up instantly, displaying an output identical to what they could see on the giant digital display that took up so much of the room.

"Doc explained to you all that everything in here is connected and sealed off, right? The only place you can book jobs is in Sanctum, and then only by using one of these special stations."

Everyone nodded. Stasis punched the corner of her screen, bringing up a new display. This one was actually curiously familiar to Tori, and when she realized why, it nearly took the breath out of her. The form Stasis had brought up, while it certainly had its differences, had unquestionably been patterned after the dozen or so she'd dealt with daily at Vendallia. The

same person had clearly designed both—which, now that she thought about it, might be Doctor Mechaniacal himself.

“The actual booking is pretty easy. You just go through each section of this piece by piece, and at the end, you’ve got a job ready for the council to review. You four will get that part expedited since you’re on a clock, but normally you have to make a special case or wait a few days. So, moving down the list, let’s start with the biggest thing first: what’s your target?”

Lance stepped forward, as it was he who’d uncovered the target they’d all agreed was the most tempting. “The Dash City Museum. It has a Level Three security system and enough art to easily hit our target half-million.”

Stasis tapped a blank spot on the form, bringing up a search function. She quickly entered “Dash City Museum” and a map appeared in front of her. Above it was a text box, visibly filled with information about the potential target. “Hmmm. Well, it’s not affiliated with the guild, which is a big one, and I don’t see any known associates of capes that work there, though the council will double check that part, but you’ve got a major problem right off the bat.” Stasis leaned back, allowing them all to get a clear view of the red, highlighted text at the top of the information box.

“Right now, they have a collection of jewels recovered from the attempted Cernovian invasion a few years back. Those things are worth a literal fortune, so the whole place has been put on extra high-alert. I bet they have capes on hand around the clock just waiting for someone dumb enough to try and steal those things.”

“We know,” Beverly said. “That’s why we picked this target.”

Stasis’s eyes widened, but before she could ask, Beverly stretched out her hand and pointed to a section just below the red warning text. “The exhibit ends on Monday when the jewels get transported to their next stop on the tour. We want to do the job on Wednesday, after they and the extra security are long gone and the staff has let their guard down.”

“Oh, that’s cunning. You’re hitting them right when they think the real risk has passed. I’m impressed.” Stasis tapped a green button on the

bottom of the screen. The display shrank back to the form page, only now the “Location” section had been filled in.

“Even on their slowest day, there’s enough art to hit our quota,” Lance said. “So we don’t need the gems. We can be perfectly happy with a paltry half-million.”

“You say that now,” Stasis muttered, quickly filling the section of the form marked “Date” with a few keystrokes. “Well, Dash City is in North Carolina. That puts you plenty of states away from the AHC’s headquarters, so that’s a step in the right direction. Should I assume you want to book Tunnel Vision for transportation?”

“Please,” Tori said. “We talked about heading there via train or car, but it would take a while to get from Colorado to North Carolina. Plus, it would leave a trail, and even if it wouldn’t be crazy suspicious, I don’t think any of us wants to wear a costume for several days straight.”

“You’re not wrong there. Those things need to be washed regularly or they can get funky.” Stasis skimmed through the form to see which section they should go over next. “I’ll show you how to handle asking for other members when we’re done, but obviously, that isn’t coming into play since it’s just you four on this job. You’ve still got two hundred bucks left in your resource account; did you want to spend it on anything?”

“I think we’ll hang on to that in case any incidentals come up,” Warren said.

“Works for me. Then that means you’ve knocked out the where, the when, the assets you need from the guild, and what resources you’re using to pay for them.” Stasis double checked her form then turned to Tori, who was still clutching the bundle of handwritten pages. “Normally, we ask that you submit tactical plans digitally on the station, but for you all, we’ll make an exception. If you give me what you’ve got, I can have it in front of the council before lunch.”

“It’s not really done yet. We did only have a night,” Tori protested.

“Plans always change, if not after you give them to us then certainly when you’re out on the job. We don’t look them over to see if every single

detail is perfect; we're just checking for any glaring mistakes or blatant violations of the code. So long as your outline doesn't have either of those, it will be fine. In this case, even if you do, we'll just ask you to make some changes. Trust me, you want to hand those over; otherwise you'll spend every hour from now until the deadline endlessly tweaking them. Better to get some feedback and maybe a little sleep."

Tentatively, Tori extended the stack of pages that she and the others had been up all night working on. Stasis, sensing the younger woman's apprehension, accepted them as if they were made of glass and tucked them securely against her arm.

"Okay: let me show you a few more functions on the form, then you can all feel free to go rest. Unlike me, the rest of the council does need to sleep, so they won't be up and able to meet until this afternoon at the soonest."

Tori didn't bother to correct her, but she knew Stasis was at least partly off-base. After all, Tori had never encountered anyone who rose with the sun quite as regularly as Ivan Gerhardt. In fact, despite the early hour, she'd have put down money that he was in his kitchen right now, cooking up a huge breakfast that he'd miraculously devour.

To Tori's credit, she was spot on about Ivan already being awake, though she could hardly be faulted for getting the location wrong. Not when Ivan had gone to such great lengths to keep it secret from her.

\* \* \*

The sounds of Penelope's cartoons wafted through the open door into the kitchen where Ivan and Helen sat drinking their coffee. She could be heard singing along, off-key, to the more musical ones, no doubt spilling her own breakfast on the floor when the urge to dance overtook her. Despite the noise, Ivan was thankful for her active participation in television viewing; it made it easier to keep track of where she was. This was not a conversation either of them wanted Penelope overhearing.

"He seemed pretty sure," Ivan said, picking at the last of the eggs left on his plate. "Said it went down that way in almost every universe."



“Even if that’s true, ‘almost every’ sort of belies the real scale. I mean, the best estimates say there are millions, maybe billions, that would be similar enough to ours to be recognizable,” Helen pointed out. “So saying ‘almost every universe’ follows a pattern is the same as saying there are hundreds of thousands that don’t. Maybe we’ll be one of those.”

“Nexus is a crazy son of a... bad man.” Ivan’s curse withered on his tongue as Helen glared at him. Whether the girl was in earshot or not, Helen didn’t allow cursing in the same house as Penelope. Given how quickly she picked up on words, Ivan could hardly blame her for the policy. “Nexus is insane, but his warnings are usually accurate.”

“Except when he’s lying, either for a purpose or for fun. Look at how many times he caused widespread destruction and blamed it on that poor Stasis woman just to make her appear to be a criminal. He can’t be trusted. While the warning is nice, I’m not going to take it as gospel.” Helen finished off her cup of coffee then took the pot from the middle of the table and refilled it halfway.

She was right, which wasn’t exactly new, but Ivan was determined to make her take it more seriously. “But Helen, if the stars fall—”

“Then they fall, Ivan. We’ve always known it was a possibility.” Helen’s eyes turned from him to the doorway into the living room, through which her daughter could still be heard singing off-tune. “I never thought this was possible, not after the accident. But you made it happen. If not for you, I don’t know that I could have even taken the first nine months, let alone the six years after that. It’s been wonderful, like living a dream. And if that dream finally comes to an end, well, I got six years of this peaceful life when I never expected a day of it. I can’t be mad that I didn’t get more; that would be just plain greedy.”

When she looked back at Ivan, Helen’s eyes had begun to water at the edges. They both pretended not to notice. Instead, Ivan reached over and took her hand in his. It was so strange to hold a thing that seemed so delicate yet was in fact one of the strongest hands in the world.

“Our universe is our own. If there’s any way to stop the stars from falling, I’ll find it. Trust me, and don’t act rashly just because things look bad.”

Helen snorted, quickly turning her head to cover the sound. “It’s still funny, you know, even after this long. You asking me to trust you. I do, don’t get me wrong, but... you know.”

“I know,” Ivan assured her. He released her hand and sank his fork into his eggs, finishing the last of them. As he chewed, a thought popped into his brain, another memory from the night before that had taken far lower precedence in light of Nexus’s prediction. “Let me ask you something: did you know that Quorum is the only one of his kind? Or does he know that? Nexus let it slip last night.”

“Oh yeah, he’s known for decades. It’s why Nexus became his arch-enemy to begin with. Apparently, he’s got a thing for the anomalies that only exist in single dimensions.” Helen put her newly freed hand back on her cup of coffee and took a sip, wincing at the burst of heat. “You know Stasis is one too, right? Evidently he mentioned that to Quorum a while ago, but we assumed she knew.”

“That one we were aware of,” Ivan said. “Not sure why he tormented her but forged a rivalry with Quorum.”

“Don’t try to understand Nexus. Nexus understands Nexus and he’s freaking insane,” Helen said.

As they chuckled at that, both noticed that the racket from the living room was dying down, meaning they’d have to weather a bout of commercials before Penelope’s next cartoon came on. Both had just managed to shove away their plates before she came rocketing in, leaping up into her mother’s lap without even bothering to see if she could successfully avoid hitting the table. Ivan smiled as he watched her land. She truly was fearless.

Just like her mother.

## Chapter 60

Tori found herself with the last thing she'd expected to possess over the weekend: free time. With their plan under review, there wasn't much point in doing more work, at least not until they knew they'd been approved for the time and target they'd chosen. After all, it would suck to spend a full day plotting out how to rob a museum that they weren't allowed to touch. Plus, there was no training to do since all of their time had been set aside to plan their job. So after a few hours of precious sleep and a quick lunch from a vending machine, Tori decided it was time to make good on another duty she'd been putting off.

It took five full minutes of knocking on Beverly's door before she finally answered, hair splayed out in all directions as she tried futilely to blink the sleep out of her eyes. After staring at Tori for several seconds, she finally opened her mouth and spat out a greeting.

"Whasmacha?"

"Eloquent as always," Tori replied. "Come on, it's been like five hours, you have to be caught up on sleep by now."

Slowly, Beverly reached up and rubbed her face until her eyes finally focused on the intruder in front of her. "The human body needs eight hours, usually. And it's not supposed to stay up for an entire night before getting them. What do you even want? There's no way the council already came back with approval."

"Shit no, I bet half of them are still lazing about like you," Tori said. "I'm actually about to head out, and I wanted to see if you were up for coming along. Figured this would be a good time to introduce you to... well, that woman I told you about."

Though she'd brought Beverly up to speed about Chloe and her predicament earlier in the week, Tori had made a point of not saying the barista's name on guild property. Perhaps it was paranoia—she highly doubted the guild would try to strong-arm Chloe into joining—but

something inside her demanded that she play her friend's secret close to the vest. If her time with Ivan had taught her one thing, it was the code. But if it had taught her two, then it was the code and when to trust her instincts.

"Right... right, the lady with the talking thing." Beverly's brain was sluggish but seemed to be kicking into gear. "Magic one, right?"

"That's the best guess. She's not a thousand percent sure where she got her powers from, but magic fits the best." Tori had tried to keep things as vague as possible, which hadn't been hard given how little Chloe actually knew about her own abilities. "You want to come see what we can figure out?"

"Well, I doubt I'll be able to get back to sleep." Beverly's words were nearly cut off as a giant yawn split her face, somewhat disproving her own argument. "Guess I may as well see if I can help. But you know there are people that have way more experience with magic than me, right? I just found a necklace."

"For now, I think it's less about magic than it is about puzzling through exactly how a thing works. I'll take someone smart and trustworthy over a magic expert," Tori said.

"Let's hope your friend feels the same." Beverly let out another yawn then shoved her door open to allow Tori inside. "Come on in. I just need a few minutes to get dressed. I'm not putting on anything too nice, though."

"Somehow, I think she'll be okay with that," Tori assured her.

"She'd better be. Oh, and since your intruding ass woke me up, you're stopping to get us some soda or something somewhere along the way," Beverly added.

"How about coffee?" Tori asked, barely concealing her knowing smile.

"Can't stand the stuff." Because she was turned toward her dresser, Beverly missed the shocked, pained expression that flitted across Tori's face. "Too bitter, even with cream and sugar. Give me a nice energy drink

any day.” Beverly finally pulled out a new t-shirt and looked back over to see Tori staring wide-eyed at the woman she’d thought she knew.

“What?”

“Nothing, nothing.” Tori shook her head. “Just trying to figure out if we can still be friends after that revelation.”

“Then get out and let me go back to sleep. I don’t haul myself out of bed on five hours of sleep for people who aren’t my friends,” Beverly said.

“I guess we can make it work then, somehow.” Tori slapped her hands together as another revelation struck her. “It will give me a chance to bring you around and show you how wrong you are about coffee.”

The next thing that struck Tori was not a revelation but rather the t-shirt Beverly had balled up and chucked at her. Unlike their attempts to shoot at the trash can, this time, Beverly’s aim was dead on.

\* \* \*

“It looks good.” Wade flipped through a few more pages, checking for details on how they’d circumvent the motion cameras only to find they had indeed put a plan in place. Having Lance’s bugs gang up to unplug them was a crude solution, though hard to dispute in terms of effectiveness. “Rough around the edges, albeit not as much as I expected. Ms. Rivas’s years of thievery are showing through.”

“Yeah, nothing is really jumping out at me either.” Xelas didn’t bother flipping through the pages. She’d looked at them once and had the information recorded—a benefit to having cameras for eyes. “They really did this all in a night?”

“Sure looks that way.” Stasis had a set of copies, though she’d long ago given them as much perusing as she planned to. There were other, more responsible members to handle the deep vetting.

Currently, Stasis, Morgana, Xelas, and Wade, sans Doctor Mechaniacal suit, were grouped together in the council’s chambers, overhauling the proposed plan. Technically, the meeting to evaluate its viability wouldn’t be for another few hours, as Gork’s people were naturally

nocturnal and both Ivan and Balaam had said their mornings were booked. Still, this group was the one that would do most of the actual work, ensuring that no sudden personnel changes or mergers had rendered the museum a poor target.

“Anyone found how they’re dealing with the security guards?” Morgana called, flipping through her pages. “I’m sure they know better than to leave a trail of corpses, but I’m not seeing what they want to do instead.”

“Page fourteen, under ‘planned developmental countermeasures,’” Wade informed her. “Looks like they’re going to have Glyph lay down some magic that will put the weaker-willed ones to sleep. Then Hephaestus and Pest Control are planning to handle any leftovers with poisoned insects and ranged chemical attacks.”

“Hephaestus has gear for that on hand?” Morgana asked. After seeing the apprentice whip up a sonic cannon out of a spare robot parts, she didn’t doubt the woman’s tech skills, but time was of the essence.

“She seems certain she can build it in time.” Wade had a suspicion that she would be bringing far more than just what was outlined before them. She had likely only submitted the things she felt were absolutely necessary. Back when he’d built his first meta-suit, he’d tried to cram in everything but a sausage grinder.

“I guess that’s fine, as long as she can pull it off,” Morgana said.

“No one else finds it worrying that Lance can just summon insects so toxic they knock people unconscious?” Xelas shivered, a sound like nails rattling in a steel can. “Makes me glad I don’t have skin.”

“His name is Pest Control.” When in the council, Wade was a stickler for using their members’ proper names, though even he would admit it was more for propriety than safety. “The animal world is a dangerous place and has served as inspiration for many a nightmare of mankind. That’s only become more true since the discovery of metas, as we’ve found all sorts of creature not previously dreamed of.”

“Wait, hold on, can Lance—sorry, Pest Control—summon meta-insects?” Stasis seemed to show interest for the first time since she’d dropped off the copies of the apprentices’ proposal.

“From what we’ve seen, he can summon any insect so long as he has seen a sample in person,” Wade replied. “Granted, that means he has little more in his meta-summoning arsenal than the augmented wasps the capes drove out of the city a few years ago, but I suspect that won’t always be the case.”

“Kids today, just full of surprises.” Xelas leaned her head back and stared at the ceiling for several seconds before speaking again. “Okay, I just finished rechecking all our databases. So far as I can tell, there’s no one directly related to AHC members or the guild that works at the Dash City Museum.”

“Thank you, Xelas.” Wade turned the last page and set it down, then clapped all the paper together into a neat pile. “We will still have to conduct a formal review this afternoon, but barring one of the other three seeing something we missed, I think it’s safe to say that come next Wednesday, the Dash City Museum will be at risk of losing quite a few exhibits.”

\* \* \*

“Maybe ‘the devil is in the details’? Wait, scratch that. On the off chance you actually can somehow create a biblically powerful supernatural enemy, I’d like to have a little more firepower than just us on hand,” Beverly said.

“No, we should try it. That’s one I’ve never tested.” Chloe took a deep breath, looked around to make sure no one had somehow snuck up on them, and whispered, “The devil is in the details.”

All three women scanned their surroundings, waiting for some horned entity to pop up from behind the heaps of scrap. After getting dropped off by a guild car at Ridge City Grinders, Tori and Beverly had joined Chloe, who drove them out to a scrapyard Tori had used as a testing ground for more experimental slip-shod weaponry once upon a time. It was the sort of place that was neglected when anyone even bothered to show up, so it offered a precious commodity in the metropolis of Ridge City: privacy.

“How do we know if it worked?” Tori asked, after several moments passed with no fallen angel popping into existence.

“I don’t know, which I think might be the problem.” Chloe pulled a small notebook from her pocket, along with a stub of a pencil, and scrawled the new phrase inside. Once it was written, she promptly drew a line through it, indicating that it hadn’t worked. “It’s starting to look like I can’t just use a phrase; there needs to be some kind of understanding with it. Saving a penny, I understand. How the devil would pop out of the details... I’ve got nothing. Maybe if there were a contract, and he could use it as a portal.” Chloe added a star next to the crossed out phrase, her way of noting that it might be worth exploring later.

So far, they’d spent over an hour with Chloe testing every idiom or old saying that popped into their minds. Several worked but many produced no visible effect, not even when adding that extra bit of magical weight to her words. It was a confusing, sometimes contradictory process, and Tori could see why Chloe was having so much trouble getting a grip on her power. It made turning into living fire seem positively mundane.

“Okay, I’ve got another one I want you to try,” Beverly said. “How about ‘one punch will send you flying’?”

Chloe tilted her head slightly. “I’ve never heard that one before.”

“But you can picture how it would work, right?”

“Well, sure. It’s pretty straightforward. One punch will send you flying.” Nothing happened as Chloe spoke, though that much had been expected. Sometimes the triggers to her magic were more obvious than others; this one would obviously demand physical contact.

“Good, now punch me. Not too hard, just one in the shoulder.” Beverly approached and paused a few inches away from Chloe.

“Hang on, what if this actually works?” Tori asked.

“Then I’ll turn into a graceful white dragon and take control of the flight.” Beverly, to Tori’s shock, had given Chloe a rundown of her powers as soon as they met. Evidently, she felt it wrong to learn so much about someone else’s secret without offering up a bit of her own. That had, in



turn, prodded Tori to provide Chloe with some insight into her fire-based abilities, though she'd kept more than a few bits still secret. "Now make with the jab."

Chloe pulled back her right arm, bunched her hand into a poorly-formed fist that would probably result in a broken finger if she put any force into the blow, and gave Beverly a light slug in the shoulder. Aside from the soft thud of flesh striking cloth, nothing happened. Beverly hadn't even shifted, let alone flown into the air.

"Interesting," Beverly said, looking down at the bony fist still resting against her shoulder. "Okay, so I think I have a theory, but it's a rough one. I mean, *really* rough. So if I'm way off base, no one hold it against me."

"At this point, I'll take any bit of information I can get," Chloe said, pulling back her fist and giving it a light shake.

"My guess—and I do want to stress that this is a guess—is that you somehow tap into something like people's belief, only with words instead of the divine. Like... okay. We know there are divine metas out there, aside from the ones who just take old-god names like Apollo. There are some who seem like they're actually drawing from something bigger than themselves—like that cape named Archbishop, for instance. But some people don't believe they're drawing from actual gods; instead, they're tapping into the collective human belief in those gods. If that's true, then why couldn't you do the same with words?"

"You lost me so far back that I might as well not have even gotten in the car," Tori said.

"This is the kind of shit you have to learn about when your power is magical and the source is unknown," Beverly replied.

"Hang on," Chloe said, squinting a bit as she puzzled together the theory Beverly had lain out before her. "So the sayings only work if a lot of people believe they work? But no one actually believes that lying will set your pants on fire, and I've used that one before. Turned a pair of jeans into ashes."

Tori made a note to inquire further about that incident; it wouldn't really do to have Chloe accidentally lighting people up all over town. That was the sort of thing that drew the attention of the capes, or worse, the guild.

"I did say it was rough," Beverly reminded her. "But I don't think it matters as much that they think it will happen literally; it's just that people keep saying them over and over, and on some level, they believe there's a sort of truth to them. Like that lying a lot will eventually land you in trouble, which is also known as a hot seat. Every time someone out there says it, they put a little more faith in it, like water through a prayer wheel. I think once those words get strong enough, you can tap into them."

Tori was slowly starting to catch on, her mind subbing out words like "faith" for "unknown variables" to keep things clearer. "Then why have her try the punching one? That's not a saying anyone says."

"It is, it's just not a common one," Beverly corrected. "People say things like that in fights when talking about people who can knock you off your feet in a single blow. One of my brothers boxes, and I've heard it used more than once. The thing is that it's not something everyone knows or thinks of offhand. That's what I wanted to test—if any saying worked, or if it needed a certain amount of saturation for Chloe to use it."

"That does explain a lot. I've tried a few sayings my grandpa used to like and only some of them worked." Chloe flipped through her notebook, looking at the successes and failures one by one, checking to see if Beverly's theory about the pattern played out. "But there are ones like 'the devil in the details' that fizzle too, and that's a pretty popular one."

"And you can probably use it if you ever find a situation that fits," Beverly said. "It looks like as much as the words need power, they also need you to shape them. If you can't picture how a saying would work in real life, even subconsciously, then you can't invoke it."

"Think of it like a gun." Tori ignored the fearful look that darted across Chloe's face and continued with her analogy. "The power is the bullet—not enough juice in the words? No bullet to fire. But your mind is the trigger. If it can't give the idea shape then the bullet just sits idly in the chamber."

“Well, well, little miss science is finally catching on,” Beverly said.

“Once you moved into parameters and execution, I was back on solid ground,” Tori shot back.

“Interesting as this is, and please don’t think for a second that it isn’t, how does it help me control this damn power?” Chloe asked.

“No idea. And honestly, it might not.” Beverly shrugged, her shoulders bobbing up and down in an unapologetic display of uncertainty. “All I know is what I was taught by my teacher, and he said that understanding is the first step to control. It worked for me, sort of, but we’ve got very different powers. At least you found a list of new things you can say without lighting pants on fire, though.”

“There is that.” Chloe sighed and snapped her notebook shut, stuffing it back into the rear pocket of her dark slacks. “I really appreciate you both taking the time to help me, even if I will still have to pick my words carefully for a while. Just having some sort of idea of what’s happening to me makes it a little easier to cope with.”

“Don’t sweat it,” Beverly said. “We metas have to stick together, you know?”

“Tell me about it. Especially those of us trying to live under the radar,” Chloe agreed. “You know Tori shot herself in the arm four times rather than tip off me and Donald that she was a meta?”

Tori blushed in spite of herself, tan cheeks quickly turning red. While she’d given Beverly something of a synopsis of what happened during the robbery, Tori had opted out of providing a full play-by-play. Part of that was in order to keep from looking like a braggart, but the rest was fearing that someone would point out a much simpler solution that she’d overlooked.

“And the thing is, I totally get it,” Chloe continued. “I just have this weird word ability and it’s hard enough to keep under wraps. Having fire manipulation... you’d have to go all out to keep your secret. There’s no way the AHC wouldn’t try to snap you up like they did Donald. Or worse, some gang that wanted to make you use your power for them.”

Tori and Beverly certainly did not exchange knowing glances at that last option; both were old and mature enough to understand that such a gesture would betray the very secret they hoped to keep. They did, however, both go for the nervous-laugh reaction, which was certainly off-putting. Seconds after she started, Tori let her laughter trail off. She decided that words might work a bit better for their situation.

“I doubt stuff like that really happens, at least around here. I mean, the AHC’s headquarters is only twenty minutes from our office. I can’t imagine how ballsy or careless any kind of gang would have to be to pull that stuff in Ridge City.” Ballsy, careless, or specifically founded and watched over by a mix of geniuses and veteran villains. Tori was just grateful that Chloe’s last phrase hadn’t been the pants-on-fire one.

“You never know, it’s a dangerous world,” Chloe said. “But hey, I never thought to ask: since we all try and keep things so secret, how did you two even find each other?”

This, at least, they’d prepared for. Beverly launched into the story they’d chosen without a moment’s hesitation. “I was changed on the same night as you, during that weird storm. I had pretty much no control of my powers, and Tori happened upon me when I was in my dragon-form. She helped calm me down, telling me she’d been there and it would be okay. Basically talked me through it until I managed to get back to human. After that, our secrets were pretty much out to each other.”

“If I hadn’t seen her shoot herself and then charge a really strong meta, I wouldn’t believe it, but Tori does seem like the type to try and calm down a dragon.” Chloe glanced down at her watch, eyes growing wide as she realized for the first time how much time had passed. “Shit. As much as I appreciate you both helping me out, I need to get back to the coffee shop. Gwen gets off soon, and if I’m not back by then, we’ll be shorthanded.”

“No problem, you can just drop us downtown and be there...” Beverly trailed off and a wide, unexpected grin suddenly appeared on her face. “Chloe, have you ever tried using your ability to teleport?”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean,” Beverly replied, walking over and taking the barista’s slender hand, “that if you’re willing to do one more test, we might all be there in a hop, skip, and a jump.”

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## Chapter 61

Teleporting with Chloe was nothing like changing locations with Tunnel Vision. While the duo opened portals between spaces, Chloe's version warped the world around them like a strange vertigo roller coaster. Additionally, hers took a little trial and error as they worked out exactly what constituted the difference between a hop, skip, and jump. Eventually, they figured it out, as well as that Chloe could take along passengers so long as they held her hand and did the motions, which led to them jumping up in the scrap yard and coming down in the parking lot behind Chloe's coffee shop.

It was a testament to their willpower that Beverly managed not to throw up at all after watching the world spin about beneath them and that Tori only dry-heaved for a minute or so. Chloe, on the other hand, was entirely unaffected. This seemed to speak to a sort of protection from her own power, though it was also possible that she just had a stronger stomach than Tori or Beverly. Unfortunately, there was still another teleport required of them, as they realized Chloe had parked her car at the scrap yard. This time no one got sick, though Beverly's skin turned green for a reason that had nothing to do with her dragon necklace.

Eventually, Chloe dropped them off downtown, where they walked for fifteen minutes to the unassuming office that camouflaged the guild's headquarters. While they could have had Chloe leave them closer by, both felt it was best to keep her as far from the guild as possible, both literally and metaphorically. Besides, after two teleports and a car ride, a walk was just what they needed to settle their stomachs.

By the time they made it back to the floor where their rooms were, both were feeling a lot better, if not fully at a hundred percent functionality. Nice as it was to have a non-guild friend that could teleport, there was an unspoken agreement that they wouldn't be looking to Chloe for transportation unless it was absolutely necessary.

“And there they are, returned at last.” Tori had barely stepped off the elevator when Lance appeared, wide grin betraying the news he’d no doubt hoped to spring on them.

“Did you already hear back from the council?” Tori asked.

Lance’s smile dimmed for a moment before he let out a sharp laugh. “You sure know how to take the wind out of someone’s sails, don’t you? Yeah, we got word about half an hour ago. The plan is temporarily approved, although we also got sent a whole list of other details we’re supposed to provide. Minutia stuff plus contingency plans, that sort of thing.”

“Hot damn!” Tori said, turning to high-five Beverly, who let out a whoop of excitement. “Look at that! Only a night to plan and we already got approved. I’d say that’s a pretty fucking good sign, wouldn’t you?”

“It’s an indication that we’re on the right path; nothing more, nothing less.” Warren stepped out from around the corner, appearing so suddenly that he nearly made Tori gasp. Then again, that might have been because of how haggard the poor guy looked. If he’d bothered to take in any sort of rest after they submitted the plan, it didn’t show. His eyes were bloodshot, his skin was paler than normal, and he had something of a sway in the way he stood that made it seem like he might tumble over at any given moment.

“Good god, did you get any sleep at all?” Beverly’s tone had lost its usual edge, the concern in her voice catching everyone off guard.

“There will be time for sleep later. I spent my time more wisely, receiving instruction from my mentor.” Warren was clearly trying to snap at Beverly, but between his own exhaustion and her unexpected sincerity, he just wasn’t able to muster up the verbal venom. “Balaam was kind enough to spend several of his precious hours teaching me further.”

Neither Beverly nor Tori said anything, because what was there to say? Their mentors were more or less in charge of them; if Balaam wanted to drive his apprentice into sleep-deprivation to give him more lessons, then that was probably his prerogative. Deep down, Tori felt a twist of guilt in her stomach as she watched Warren fight to stay conscious. Before she

came, apprentices had fallen out of style. If she hadn't gotten paired with Ivan, Warren wouldn't be apprenticed to a sociopath.

"As great a learning opportunity as that was, I think we're all ready to start working on answering the council's questions," Lance said, slapping Warren lightly on the back. "I'll bring the girls up to speed. Why don't you grab a computer, head to the lounge, and start doing some research on which exhibits should be our prime targets?"

Warren gave a half-nod, too tired to argue, and stumbled off down the hall. Once he was gone, Lance turned back to Tori and Beverly. "I figure as soon as he sits on that couch, he'll pass clean out. I feel bad asking, but do you mind if we let him nap for a while? We're technically ahead of schedule, and I'm afraid if he's not with us, Balaam will just find excuses to keep him awake."

"I really hate that fucking guy," Tori muttered darkly. "What reason does he have to torment his own apprentice?"

"Apparently he's trying to force Warren to flip his schedule so he'll get used to being awake at night," Lance explained. "Magic requires mental clarity, so he doesn't want Warren to be all groggy when we're actually out on the job."

"Huh. That's actually a lot more practical than I was expecting," Beverly admitted.

"Pretty sure our mentors can't torture us for no reason, not even here," Lance said. "I mean, we're a guild of villains. None of us are big on taking shit from people. Pointless cruelty to an apprentice is a recipe for someone coming after you down the line, though I agree that there were probably less asshole-ish ways to go about this one."

"Either way, we'll pull Warren's share of the weight until he's gotten a few hours of rest." Tori mentally flipped through her to-do list, which, now that Chloe had a starting point for figuring out her power, left only the day job, finishing the plan, and her meta-suit. The last one was out until the weekend was over or until they had a final plan approved, which meant she needed to put all her energy into getting every facet of their robbery outlined either way.



“You do need to bring us up to speed though, Lance. If we’ve still got shit to do, I want to meet it head on. We’re starting off ahead of schedule; let’s stay there. I’ve got my own prep work to finish.”

“Ah yes, the legendary technological revelation that will be your suit,” Beverly said. “Are you sure you’re going to be able to have that ready in time? We’ve only got a few days left.”

“Trust me,” Tori assured her. “Come hell or high water, no matter the cost, even if I have to work looking as tired as Warren, I am going to get my suit done. This is more than just our last trial, you know. It’s our first time out as genuine representatives of the guild.”

Tori turned and headed down the hall after Warren, mind already set on the sole task barring her from her workshop.

“I intend to make sure Hephaestus is dressed properly for her first night on the town.”

\* \* \*

“As I’m sure you know, our security systems’ current framework was put in when the Alliance of Heroic Champions was officially founded.” Quorum didn’t break stride as he spoke, walking down the long, red-carpeted hallway without missing a step. Given the level of multi-tasking he was capable of, this technically required barely more effort than simply lying on the ground. “Professor Quantum installed it to ensure that every superhero we recruited had at least one place in the world they could feel safe. No mad villain or vengeful criminal would ever break through these walls. Here, if nowhere else in the world, we could find a measure of peace.”

Apollo did, in fact, know all of this, but said nothing as he followed Quorum down the hallway. He understood that this was more a matter of ceremony than history, and did his part by being respectfully silent.

“Of course, the system has had countless updates since then, both in reaction to attempts to attack us and as a result of breakthroughs Professor Quantum has had. Overall, I’d say about once a year our defenses get an upgrade. One thing, however, has remained eternally constant.”

Quorum reached the end of the hallway, passing three portraits labeled with a golden placard that read “Founders,” and opened a simple, unassuming door. What waited inside was a sharp contrast to the quaint, dated hall they’d traversed. It was nothing but light and metal, a cylinder enclosed on all sides with only a single button-less terminal occupying the center of the floor. Moving slowly, Quorum stepped inside and motioned for Apollo to follow. No sooner had he passed the door than it closed smoothly behind him. Despite the fact that there was barely a click, Apollo had a hunch that, even with his impressive power, breaking through that door would be nearly impossible.

“Since the AHC’s founding, the only members to have our security system’s highest level of access have been myself, Professor Quantum, and Lodestar. While we trust our members with much, there is also a great deal that is simply too dangerous. The holding cells where we confine metas until prisons can adequately prepare for them, the technology we’ve confiscated from civilizations both terrestrial and space-faring, the myriad of objects that would induce meta-powers deemed too dangerous to be allowed out into the world, you get the idea. It was decided that those with full access to such facilities was best kept limited specifically to those on, or with, the Champions’ Congress. But you’ve seen all those places before.”

Apollo had indeed; he’d long ago reached the point where he was trusted to drop off criminals to the cells or trinkets to the vaults. Tempting as they were, he had never felt the desire to abuse his privileges. There was no need in him to deal with criminals beyond bringing them to justice, foreign technology was most dangerous to those using it without knowing how, and anyone who’d been around metas for more than a few months learned that mixing power sources was a fool’s game. Tools were one thing, but the objects that could induce meta-abilities were best kept at one per person. At best, two canceled each other. At worst, all manner of unexpected effects occurred. No, Apollo had taken his privileges seriously and treated them with respect. Accessing those little nooks and crannies hidden in the AHC was never his end goal.

“This, as I’m sure you’ve guessed by now, is a bit different. We don’t broadcast its existence with grand schematics or cumbersome doors.

This is the heart of our system, the only place where serious, permanent changes can be made. The three of us have remote terminals that can grant temporary clearances or operate the system, but those have strict limitations. We wouldn't want anyone hacking or stealing them and causing trouble. That's why we have this heart, this solemn chamber where only those specifically chosen can enter. And like any true heart, it is both delicate and powerful."

Quorum moved to the center of the room where the button-less terminal stood. As he moved close, a hatch opened and a single object, like an egg on a pole, rose upward. "In here, and only here, true change can occur. As of today, you will be the first non-founder to have permissions within this room. You will have full access to every non-personal aspect and area and the ability to raise the permission levels of those you deem trustworthy. This is a historic day, Apollo."

"One I will remember for the rest of my life." There was no insincerity in his voice, nor would it have found a home there. Apollo truly meant those words with every fiber of his being. "But can you do this alone? I imagined the Champions' Congress would all need to be present."

"There are only three of us, Apollo, and we trust each other." Quorum pressed his index fingers to the egg. A soft glow illuminated his entire body. "The others used their remote devices to give permission for this promotion, but only one of us is necessary to carry it out. It was a function added after Lodestar was stuck in a black hole for a month and we were unable to create a temporary council replacement. Thus it was decided that one was enough, though Professor Quantum did take great pains to ensure no one could trick the system. These scanners detect everything from your DNA to your brainwaves to your dimensional footprint. Nothing is impossible, but this is as close as we've come to total security."

The glow faded, and a new hatch opened, bringing up a fresh egg-looking device in front of Apollo.

"And now, my young superhero, it's your turn. You have worked long and hard to earn this honor, so reach out and claim it as your own. Once you're scanned, you will have all the rights and privileges of a member of the Champions' Congress."

Apollo didn't need to be told twice. He reached out his hands, noting that the glow cascading over him was almost chilly. All that work, all those years, and now, at last, it was finally in his hands. Literally in his hands. Such a simple, unassuming egg, but it would give him the prize he'd been after all this time. It was the last piece he'd need to begin the work superheroes were truly meant to do.

Wiping out villains.

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## Chapter 62

Ivan was surprised at how empty his house felt. When the weekend ended, he'd expected a return to normalcy, or at least the strange situation that passed for normalcy these days. But Tori had barely paused long enough to wolf down dinner before she'd buried herself back in the basement lab. Granted, she already spent a lot of time down there, but usually she'd emerge on occasion to grab a beer from the fridge and make a little small talk. This time, Ivan didn't see her again until it was time to leave for work, and she emerged from the hidden basement blinking the exhaustion out of her eyes.

Work seemed to fly by now that he'd gotten mostly caught up from his time away. Of course, he'd no sooner finished his backlog than the word came down from Mrs. Espinoza that Donald wouldn't be coming in for a week, maybe two, and that what few remaining responsibilities he still had were to be pawned off on the other programmers. This little shuffle wasn't particularly hard, especially since Ivan had prepared for the possibility as soon as Donald signed up with the AHC, but it was a bit depressing. Donald really had been one of his best employees, the right mix of smart and cowardly that meant he'd contribute to the company but never be bold enough to strike out on his own. Replacing him wouldn't be easy, but that was life in Ridge City.

If Tori was bothered by the absence of her friend, it didn't show. In fact, she barely seemed engaged with the world around her. Her work was flawless and she upheld all the expected pleasantries when greeting others in the office, but it was clear at a glance that her mind was elsewhere. Ivan could hardly blame her, given the proverbial sword dangling over her head, just days away from falling or being removed; it was a wonder she kept things as together as she did.

Tuesday was no different, Tori emerging exhausted in the morning after a hastily-eaten dinner and another night in the basement. Ivan was prepared for more of the same on Wednesday as he finished up the last of his pancakes, but to his surprise, it was a well-rested, vibrant-eyed Tori that

stepped out from behind the wall-panel. Her suit was crisp and there was a spring in her step as she descended on the table, grabbing her now cold breakfast and slathering it with syrup.

“This is a nice change,” he commented, not sure how else to broach the subject of her zombie-like state for the last few days.

“Tonight’s the big show, so I cut myself off from work at midnight and went to bed. Last minute crunch time is well and good, but I need a clear head if we want to pull off tonight’s job.” If Tori was bothered by the room-temperature pancakes, she didn’t show it, digging in like she hadn’t eaten in days. Which, really, she hadn’t—all she’d been doing before was quieting her hunger.

“A very responsible decision,” Ivan said. “Were you able to get everything done that you wanted?”

“Holy hell no. Not by a long shot.” Tori’s reply shot a few pancake crumbs across her end of the table, something that might have bothered Ivan more if his own children didn’t commit similar sins at least once a weekend. “I got the thruster system put in but couldn’t tweak the output enough to safely compensate for the combined weight of me and the suit, which means flight is off the table. I realized I didn’t have nearly enough money or parts to get my magnetic disruptor small enough, either. Actually, money and size held me back from most of the things I wanted to implement, with time tagging in as the pain-in-the-ass third.”

“Yet you seem surprisingly upbeat.”

“Well, duh. I might not have gotten everything I wanted, but I did manage the one that was the most important.” Tori’s grin was stretched from ear to ear, a combination of mischief and pride that would have left Ivan very worried if he were an enemy. As it was, it still made him mildly concerned.

“I did it, Ivan. It *worked* last night. It isn’t perfect, and there’s a lot of adjustments I need to cram in before we leave tonight, but I managed to create a successful prototype meta-suit. I can’t tell you how that feels, after so many years of half-assing my way around makeshift labs and jerry-rigging parts to test concepts. Last night, I finally did something that was

only a dream. I made my suit, Ivan. And tonight, I get to give it a genuine field test.”

“That is a very high stakes scenario to be taking your first test drive in.” Ivan didn’t try to dissuade her precisely, but he did want to be sure she’d really thought things through. Smart as Tori was, she could also get caught up in her own ambition, which was precisely what had landed her inside Wade’s vault in the first place. Having a meta-suit on the job could be a serious asset, but it could just as easily become a liability if things went awry.

“Give me a little credit here. This isn’t my first robbery,” Tori replied. “I checked everything thoroughly last night, and I’ll do another sweep before I take it out. Plus, every device we factored into the plan is detachable, meaning that even if it all goes to shit, I can salvage what we need and dump the rest. I do still have my fire powers, no matter what else happens.”

“It’s a pragmatic approach, but would you really be willing to discard something you worked so hard on?” Ivan asked.

“Sure. It’s just tech.” Tori grabbed the syrup and squeezed the last few drops out, drawing desperate wheezes from the collapsing plastic. “The important part is the design and testing. Once I’ve actually got my schematics, rebuilding is just a matter of supplies and time. Though it would take me a while to save up enough to make another. Getting that prize money from our desert fight helped out a lot.”

“Somehow I think you could make it work with a hundred and twenty-five thousand dollars.” Ivan happened to tilt his glass of orange juice up at that moment, so it wasn’t until several seconds later that he saw the stunned, dumbstruck face of his apprentice staring at him. “What?”

“What do you mean, what? You just casually mention the idea of me getting over a hundred grand and then don’t explain what the hell you’re talking about? Of course I’m waiting to hear more.”

It was Ivan’s turn to be puzzled as he set down his glass and met Tori’s gaze. “I’m not sure where I lost you in this discussion. It can’t have

been at the math. Dividing five hundred by four isn't exactly advanced calculus."

"Five hundred by..." Tori's voice trailed off. The syrup near the edge of her plate started to bubble, a rare slip in her control of the ambient temperature. When she found her voice again, it was strangled and choked, like she was forcing each word out one by one. "Ivan, are you saying we get to *keep* the money from tonight's job?"

"Of course you get to keep it, you're the ones who are stealing it. Minus the guild's cut, I mean. Did you think we were going to have you steal half a million dollars and then spend it on new couches or something?"

"Well, no, but it just occurred to me... I mean, we're only apprentices," Tori pointed out.

"Today, you're only apprentices. If tonight goes well, you'll be full members. This is a guild of criminals, people who don't react well to people taking what's rightfully theirs. You do the work, you keep the rewards. That's always been our policy." Ivan rose from his chair, grabbed his dishes and took them into the kitchen, where he set them in the sink. Once he returned, Tori had finished her breakfast, but now had a new, nervous aura around her.

"You look worried," he noted.

"No shit," she shot back. "You just told me that if tonight's job goes well, I'm going to get a payday of over a hundred grand. Those kind of stakes will put anyone on edge."

"As opposed to, say, knowing that if you screwed up, it would probably cost you your life?"

Tori shook her head and got up from the table, dishes in hand as she made her way to the kitchen. "You don't get it, Ivan. That was just my life. This, this is fucking *money*."

\* \* \*

"How are things?" Apollo stepped into the monitoring room—nicknamed the Chamber of Boredom by most of the other superheroes—



and spoke to one of the few members of the AHC who didn't complain when getting put on monitoring duty. Stalwart Iron sat unmoving save for the precise motions of his fingers, screening through a variety of police and emergency reports. The AHC employed more than two dozen mundane humans whose job it was to find situations that required superheroes and dispatch those who were on duty, but it was policy to always have at least one cape, if not more, on hand at all times to oversee the operation. There were certain patterns one could recognize, hunches they could follow, a kind of intuition that only came from having been out in the field personally.

"A slight uptick in activity, though nothing outside normal parameters," Stalwart Iron replied, not bothering to look at Apollo. The mechanical man, salvaged from the lair of some mad scientist that had bitten off more than he could chew by going after a cape, often left others on edge. They never quite trusted artificial intelligence, but Apollo honestly preferred it. People could be so emotional and impractical; at least Stalwart Iron was predictable. Even if he'd been gifted with agency, that agency was still made of ones and zeroes. There were limits, and that made him more useful than ninety percent of the other superheroes Apollo worked with.

"Big world out there; it never gets completely quiet," Apollo said. "Just keep me in the loop if anything unusual comes up."

"What if... what if there is something that is not happening, but that I suspect might?" Stalwart Iron still didn't face Apollo, but the rhythm of his keystrokes slowed. Now this was unexpected; Stalwart Iron was rarely hesitant, always working with the surety that only a machine could manage.

"A hunch?" Apollo walked over to look at the screen Stalwart Iron had been working on.

"A theory, or perhaps a pattern that plays out irregularly," Stalwart Iron replied. "As you can see on the graph, criminal activities go through simple, very general cycles: increasing during hotter months, frequency dropping during the day, variables along those lines. However, in reviewing previous records, I noticed that sometimes, not always, we will see fluctuations like those that have come over the past week. Sudden, small events that seem random, followed by a brief pattern of diminished activity,

which ends with a flurry of crime that stretches our personnel and resources thin. They don't flag anything in the system, though, because when the dust settles, there is almost always a minimum of collateral damage. But at least one high-end theft or robbery will have occurred in the chaos."

"I get it; someone fills the sky with smoke so we can't find the actual fire." Apollo scanned the graph that Stalwart was showing him, most of it little more than lines on a page. He'd never had a great head for numbers and he knew it, which was why he surrounded himself with people who didn't share his weakness. "And you think we're on track for one of these incidents?"

"I only know that it's possible. Even when all the lead up is there, the pattern only fully executes roughly forty percent of the time," Stalwart Iron replied. "However, if in the next five hours we see a significant drop-off, it would be entirely possible that we'll soon be hit by an influx of problems."

"I'm glad you brought this to my attention," Apollo said, gently patting Stalwart Iron's metal shoulder. He wasn't sure if the metal skin conducted touch or if the sentiment came through, but since Stalwart Iron seemed to understand human gestures, Apollo made a point of using them on him. "If the dip occurs, I want you to let me know right away. No matter what I'm doing, get in touch with me. Can you do that?"

"Yes, sir." Stalwart Iron nodded.

"Good man," Apollo said, his golden glow brightening in visible joy. "Thanks to that brain of yours, I've got a hunch of my own. Tonight, we're going to catch us a whole batch of brand-new villains."

\* \* \*

A soft hiss filled the lab as Tori's left gauntlet locked in place on the coupler that ended at her elbow. She flexed her fingers, testing the responsiveness, and watched as the black metal hand covering her own matched her movements. With a moment of focus, she turned her hand to living fire and repeated the motion, nearly squealing with delight as the gauntlet obeyed her motion just like it had when flesh and bone were giving the orders.

Since she needed her fire to refuel the suit's batteries, and because the less corporeal she was the safer she was, it had been vital to find a way to manipulate her suit while in fire-form. After a lot of trial and error, she'd finally hit on the idea of using an inner material that not only converted her heat to energy but also measured the temperature at every point of contact. Since the core parts of her burned hotter, when she pressed a flaming finger to a spot in the gauntlet, it responded the way it would if it were the pressure of her flesh trying to move it. Admittedly, the system wasn't as precise as she wanted it to be, but a hundred thousand dollars would buy more than enough components to fine tune the mechanism.

Allowing her hand to go back to normal, Tori rose from her seat, noting that her heavy steps echoed off the walls. With a quick flick on her belt, she activated the noise cancellation system, designed to match and destroy every sound her suit made before it could travel more than three inches from the source. Another step, and this time there was silence. She left it functioning until she made it across the room then turned it off. Handy a tool as it was, the damn thing gobbled power, so it was best used only when needed.

Tori was near her work table where the final piece of her project awaited her when she caught sight of herself in the mirror. It likely wouldn't have even registered to her, except that the person staring back was so foreign that for a moment, she thought she was being attacked. The high-pitched whine of weapons readying filled the air before her brain caught up to her reactions and Tori forced herself to relax. She was on edge; that was the only explanation for readying an attack on her own reflection. Then again, she couldn't blame herself. The person staring back at her was a far cry from what Tori Rivas normally saw in the mirror.

Gone was the business attire of Tori the intern and the default costume of Tori the apprentice. This woman wore a suit of black metal, with a few red accents added on in a manner she liked to think was tasteful. The suit covered her from the neck down, occasionally bulky and misshapen enough to betray that she'd focused on functionality over design. Oddly, the asymmetrical bits and disproportional lumps didn't bother her, nor did the knowledge that only two hours of hard work had tucked away the last of the wires that had hitherto been exposed. She'd have plenty of

time to refine the design, to make it sleek and cool and the sort of thing that would set other tech geeks' hearts aflutter. But there was something special about this suit, about her first functioning prototype. Ugly as it was, she knew it would always have a place in her heart that the other iterations could only try to live up to.

She reached over and picked up the final piece from her work table, a black metal helmet with red lenses covering the eyes. Slipping it on was an ordeal, only possible because she'd knotted her long hair into a tight braid. Finally, she heard the telltale click and hiss as it joined to the suit's neck. Tori looked in the mirror again, the last traces of her civilian identity now concealed. She cycled through the camera's enhanced modes, checking the night and thermal vision first then making sure the zoom functioned as well. Everything was working. One last shift to fire-form confirmed that the digital display would hold up, at least so long as she didn't crank up the temperature too much.

Tori marveled at the person in the mirror for a bit longer, amazed at how completely she'd disappeared in her own device. There was no shred of Tori remaining, neither the apprentice nor the thief nor the intern with a secret. This was someone completely new, a version of herself that had only lived in the shadows of her mind until she donned her helmet for the first time.

"Hephaestus." Her voice was purposely warped by the helmet's circuitry, made harsh and deep but still easy to understand. "It's a pleasure to meet you." It was, too. It truly, honestly was. "The guild is expecting great things from you. And I'm expecting so much more."

A knock came from the door to the basement, her sensors easily picking it up and identifying the origin. "Tori," Ivan called down from above. "It's almost time."

Hesitantly, Tori reached up and removed the helmet from her face. The rest could be covered with a large enough coat, and if they entered the car inside the garage, no one would see her strange boots. But she couldn't very well ride around in Ivan's car with her helmet on, no matter how much she disliked having to take it off.

“I’ll be up in a few seconds,” Tori yelled. She looked down at the helmet in her hands, at the face of Hephaestus, and smiled. “Soon. Just not quite yet. We have to get to the guild first. As soon as we do, I’ll introduce you to everyone. It should make for quite an entertaining start to the night.”

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## Chapter 63

Beverly hadn't exactly thought Tori was overstating her abilities after watching her cobble together a sonic cannon in the middle of the desert, but she did find it hard believe a fellow apprentice could make a functioning meta-suit with nothing more than an intern's salary, some supplies on a tab, and a few extra grand. Most people weren't that gifted, it was true; but Beverly had failed to account for Tori's resourcefulness and years spent getting by with only what she could salvage or steal.

She let out a gasp of shock as her friend walked into the familiar lounge where they'd done so much planning, clad in metal and tech everywhere but on her head. And even that was temporary, if the helmet under her left arm was any indication.

"Well, great, way to make me feel under-dressed, asshole," she quipped. Beverly's own costume was the same as Lance and Warren's, the default one she'd been given as an apprentice. Only Lance had added an accessory, a large plastic tube slung across his chest that served for function, not fashion.

"You had two days, you could have sewn something together," Tori suggested.

"Screw that. I was catching up on the sleep I missed over the weekend." She walked around Tori slowly, taking in all the strange switches and mechanisms built into the suit. Across the room, Lance and Warren were heading over to do the same, clearly marveling at the technological wonder she'd walked into their lounge.

"Why is the helmet off?" Lance asked. "And how can you operate the suit without it on? Don't you control these things with your brain?"

"Some suits work that way, but I had to go a different route," Tori replied. "And the helmet is off because we'd barely gotten in the front door when we ran into Arcanicus, who nearly hexed me. Pseudonym suggested I keep my familiar face exposed, at least until we were out on the job."

“Probably a smart call,” Beverly agreed. “So, does all this stuff really work?”

“Not everything, and not perfectly, but the gear we’ll be counting on has been checked up, down, and sideways,” Tori assured her. “And if it all goes to hell, I’ve got my apprentice costume on under here, so I can throw on the mask and still pitch in.”

“At least we’d be a matching set.” Warren looked down at his own outfit with a weary sigh. “Does the guild provide tailors? I never gave much thought to a costume before, but if I have to pull a job, I think I’d prefer something a little more... me.”

“Pretty sure the guild has everything,” Lance replied. “Long as you’ve got the cash for it.”

Warren stared at his outfit for a bit longer then raised his head. “I guess this will do for a while.”

“Or you can put your share of the money toward some nice duds.” Tori worked very hard to hide her relief at discovering she wasn’t the only one who hadn’t realized their job came with a payday. “I mean, even after the guild cut, we’re each taking home over a hundred thousand dollars. Unless you want an outfit made of diamonds, I bet you’ll be good.”

All three of her fellow apprentices stopped looking at the suit and turned their attention to the woman within. As quickly and humbly as she could manage, Tori told them that whatever they brought in that night would be theirs to keep and split per guild rules. While Lance and Warren took the news like they’d just won the lottery—which, monetarily speaking, they might as well have—Beverly narrowed her eyes and made a “tsk” sound between her tongue and teeth.

“Those crafty bastards. It’s just one trap after another with them, isn’t it?”

“Um, Beverly, we were just told we get to keep the money,” Lance said. “How is that anything but great news?”

“Because it’s meant to get us in trouble. Think about it. We get to keep all the money we score, right?”

Tori nodded. “That’s what Pseudonym told me, and since he’s on the council, I’d say that’s as close to gospel as we’re going to get around here.”

“So, we know we have to bring back a minimum of five hundred grand,” Beverly said, spinning in place so that she could look at Lance and Warren. “That’s what we planned for. We picked the exhibits that we knew would have the best ratio of low security to high yield. We even chose several backups in case something went wrong with those. Right now, the four of us have a good plan to get in and out of the Dash City Museum with just over half a million dollars. But now, that number isn’t just an arbitrary goal. It’s a payday. It’s what we’ll split once we get home.”

“All of which sounds pretty good,” Warren pointed out.

“Exactly,” Beverly agreed, giving a nod so forceful it sent a few strands of hair flying. “It sounds so good that once we’re in the museum, we might decide to up our take a little more. Maybe grab a few more exhibits, ones we weren’t going to risk grabbing before. When that goal isn’t arbitrary, suddenly restraint seems less important. After all, getting in and out are the hard parts, and that’s covered. We get greedy, we stretch ourselves thin, and we go off the plan. And that’s when we make a mistake.”

It sounded like the ravings of someone with severe paranoia... except that the more they all thought about it, the more sense Beverly’s take on things made. As soon as the money had become real, the entire mission had taken on a whole different feeling. Once they were actually there with priceless objects in arm’s reach, how tempting would it be to up their haul, just by a few thousand here and there?

“It’s not a trap,” Tori said, breaking the silence that had fallen at the end of Beverly’s rant. “I mean, it is, but it’s not really. It’s part of the test. This is supposed to see how we would act as guild members, right?”

“That’s what they told us,” Lance agreed.

“Then this is something they’d definitely need to check. When the money is real, when we’ve got genuine temptation in front of us, can we make the smart decisions instead of the greedy ones?” Tori smacked one metal-gauntlet-covered hand into the other, resulting in a clang that made



even Warren jump. “That’s an issue that will come up on every single job we pull. They’d be idiots not to have some aspect of it in our exam.”

“Meaning it’s not dickish. That’s nice of them,” Lance said.

“No, it’s still a bit dickish, I’m only saying it has a purpose,” Tori told him. “Something we didn’t even consider was being tested without us realizing it. And if there’s one element like that, there are bound to be more.”

“Just what are you getting at?” Warren asked.

“She’s saying that we treat this job like the real thing, and we stick to the plan the council approved no matter what.” Beverly had calmed down a bit after Tori’s explanation, though she still wore a wary expression as her eyes darted about the room. “We put stealth and safety above all else, we stick to the targets we know how to get, and we prioritize escaping without leaving evidence of a ruckus.”

“And when things inevitably go awry?” Lance asked. He noticed some skepticism in their faces and crossed his arms. “What? Given the points Tori and Beverly just made, there’s no way they’ll let us have a clean and easy trial. Sooner or later, something will go wrong, even if they have to make it happen, just to see how we handle ourselves when the shit hits the fan.”

“Damn it... Lance is probably right,” Tori agreed. “We can’t really plan for that, either. Just don’t panic, first off, and make sure we communicate and work together. But if ever you’re in doubt, just try and figure out something that sticks to the guild’s code. If you aren’t breaking that, then anything you do has a good shot at being okay.”

“And what if we can’t help breaking the code?” Warren asked.

Tori considered the question carefully. There was only one answer no matter how she looked at it. “Breaking the code is one of the only real crimes you can commit inside this guild. That alone is bad enough, but breaking it during a test to see if you’re responsible and smart enough to function as a guild member... we all watched what happened last Monday. You might as well kill yourself and save them the trouble.”

\* \* \*

“Nervous?” Thuggernaut took the open chair next to Ivan, who was dressed in his bland Pseudonym costume. Around them, the other mentors and members of the council milled about. Others were already seated as they waited for the large display in front of them to crackle to life. This wasn’t like the other lessons or tests where they were free to observe in whatever manner suited them best. Tonight the membership of four applicants would be determined, which meant the council had to watch it together and render an official verdict. The only other people allowed to be present were the apprentices’ mentors, called in to ensure they weren’t tempted to intervene.

“I’d rather not kill my student.” Ivan wasn’t sure how it was for the others, if they’d be handed the duty of dealing with their apprentice’s failures or if it would be pawned off on someone else to handle. Tori, however, would die by no other hand but his own. Even if no one else demanded it, even if he weren’t one of the few that could kill living fire, he would still insist upon it. As her teacher, he owed her at least that much.

“We did all we could, taught them as well as they’d learn,” Thuggernaut replied. “From here on out, it’s all up to them.”

“If that were true, I’d feel much easier.” Ivan’s eyes drifted across the room to Wade, who was wearing every bit of his own meta-suit except the helmet. It was sleek and dynamic, billions of dollars above the makeshift one Tori had assembled under Ivan’s house. As the guild’s leader, Wade never let an entrance test pass without throwing a curveball or two. It was a sound policy that Ivan agreed with in principle—seeing how one reacted under pressure was equally important to seeing how well they could craft a plan. But that was in principle. Now that Ivan had a student of his own about to be thrust into chaos, he found himself wondering just how necessary that policy really was.

“I’ve been here a long time, and I’ve seen more guild applicants come through than I’d have cared to.” Thuggernaut gazed at the still-empty screen as if he could get a sneak peek of what was to come just by staring hard enough. “Nothing in this world is certain, but our kids have a shot. A

good one at that. And they've already learned to work together, which gives them a big leg up."

"It's possible," Ivan said. "But there's another way to look at it. Because they have already figured out the importance of acting as a cohesive unit, Doctor Mechaniacal will factor that in and increase the difficulty of his unexpected variables proportionally."

Thuggernaut's wide face drooped, and a few shades of color left his skin. "You're saying..."

Ivan nodded grimly. "I'm saying that them being so exceptional may ultimately end up getting them a much more difficult, and possibly deadly, test."

\* \* \*

Tori had expected Doctor Mechaniacal, or Ivan, or someone like Stasis or Xelas to be waiting for them as they entered Sanctum. Someone to give them last-minute reminders or a word of encouragement before their trial began. Instead, the only people behind the large door were Tunnel Vision, standing silently until it was time to fulfill the duty they'd been contracted for. Only when she saw the nearly empty room did it truly hit home: they were on their own. From this point forward, all they had was themselves, the resources they'd bought, and the plans they'd made. No one was going to be nearby if they needed help. Even Tunnel Vision's services came with the caveat that they wouldn't open a portal if it might compromise guild security.

"We have to go to the teleportation chambers," the female half of Tunnel Vision said. "Except for there, everything in Sanctum is secured from spatial anomalies."

That was all she said before she and her male counterpart both turned and moved for a door, not even bothering to see if the others were keeping up. Tori and the other apprentices hurried along, following Tunnel Vision through a series of winding hallways and passing through several well-secured doors before arriving in a room so big Tori suspected it could have easily housed a small jet.

“The security system in here is separate, so we can temporarily disable it,” the male member of Tunnel Vision explained. “We will do so now, to send you out. When your job is complete, contact us using the communication devices provided and we will open another portal, assuming we can do so securely.” As he spoke, the woman removed several small electronics from a bag at her side and passed them out. Each was small, barely bigger than a jump drive, with a single button set in the center. Curiously, there was no uniformity to them, as if they’d been made by four entirely different people. As Tori accepted hers and tucked it into a hidden compartment on her suit’s torso, she realized that they were built that way as camouflage. If they all looked different, it would be hard to link them to a central provider should they be lost.

“All you have to do is press the button,” the man continued. “Don’t worry if it happens by accident; we’ll check what’s happening before opening the portal. Even so, try not to let that happen. The moment you intentionally call us to the time the portal opens should last no longer than ten seconds. Try to stay together, and, as you should know, portals will only be opened in secure locations. You no doubt are aware from your research that the interior of the museum is too well-surveilled to count as such a location. Do you have any questions?”

Tori looked at the others, who were in turn looking at each other, all waiting to see if anyone had something to ask. When it became clear there was nothing left to be said, she lifted the helmet from under her arm and slowly lowered it past her face. This time was easier; it took only a few moments before the telltale hiss and click told her that the last piece of her suit was in place.

“Looks like it’s time to start,” Tori said, taking a few people by surprise with her altered voice. “Remember, stick to the plan if at all possible, and the code above all else. Also, from here on, villain names only until we’re back inside the guild. Let’s get this done quickly and safely.”

She turned her head to the pair of people waiting for orders and gave a small nod, barely perceptible through all the armor and tech surrounding her.

“Tunnel Vision, open it up. It’s time to go to work.”

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## Chapter 64

The Dash City Museum sat in what had once been the heart of the city's downtown district. However, zoning and cheaper properties had slowly migrated most of the offices, restaurants, and shops farther south, leaving the formerly thriving area designated as a "historic district." On top of getting less foot traffic, the buildings around the museum were not always in use. In fact, some had sat vacant for over a year.

A small structure, more shack than building, which had once housed a company that sold big scoops of ice cream on thick waffle cones, sat unassuming until a hole in space appeared and four figures stepped over from a secured building a half-dozen states away. As quickly as it had appeared, the portal vanished, leaving them alone inside the cramped shack, staring out across a small section of parking lot at their target.

"First things first, we need eyes on everything," Hephaestus announced. "Pest Control, that's you. After that, we need to get control of their exterior cameras and alarms. Glyph, you know what to do." Reaching into a compartment on her belt, Hephaestus pulled out a device that had started its life as a Walkman. She handed it to Glyph, whose right-hand fingers had already begun to glow as he traced a symbol on his left forearm. No more drawing in sand, it seemed. Whatever Hephaestus thought about Balaam, his tutelage was clearly paying off.

Her eyes carefully traced Glyph's movements as he constructed the symbol. Technically, putting the device in place would have been easier for Hephaestus, but Glyph had another job to do when he got close to the building and he could only power so many runes at a time.

Pest Control, meanwhile, had summoned dozens of flies, which were streaming one by one out of the shack on their way toward the museum. His eyes were closed as he saw through their fractured vision, a feat which was almost as impressive as summoning the creatures in the first place.

“Exterior is clear,” Pest Control relayed. “Just like we hoped, everything around is closed this late, so there’s no foot traffic. Cameras everywhere, though.”

“Shouldn’t be an issue.” Glyph finished drawing his rune. A small burst of light rippled off it. Just like that, he seemed to shimmer. Hephaestus had to strain her eyes and focus to tell that he was there. If she lost track of him, she doubted she’d be able to regain it.

He rose from his seat and stepped through the rear door, not bothering to hide his movements in the slightest. “Pest Control, can you give me a fly? I don’t know if you’ll be able to see me if I signal you once we’re clear, but I assume you can tell if I kill one of your insects.”

“Isn’t that what the comms are for?” Pest Control tapped the side of his head where a small earpiece was resting. An identical one rested in the ear of every other apprentice, save for Hephaestus, who’d simply patched her own helmet’s system in to the channel.

“Technically, yes, but until we’ve got this place secure, I’d like to avoid using them as much as possible. Secure as they are, high-end scanners exist,” Glyph pointed out.

“Better safe than sorry, I guess. Luckily, with this few insects out, I’d definitely notice losing one.” Pest Control held out his hand and a fly appeared in it. It buzzed over until it was hanging in the air before Glyph and made no move to escape as the half-visible man reached out and grabbed it. Glyph tucked it carefully away in one of the many pockets of his costume.

“Once I’ve got the box in place and the guards handled, I’ll squish it. That means you’re all clear to approach.” Then Glyph was gone, all but impossible to track as he made his way across the small stretch of empty parking lot.

This was the part Hephaestus had been dreading the most: she and Bahamut had to sit patiently and wait, unable to affect the outcome of the all-important first step. There was just no way around it, though. She’d built the tech as best she could; all she could do now was trust Glyph to get it in place. Once inside, she’d handle hacking the more complex, delicate

systems, but he was the only one who could make the first approach unseen. All they could do was be patient while Pest Control scattered his flies, the tools that would give them a surveillance system even as they disabled the one the guards depended on.

“Something I wanted to ask,” Bahamut said, her fidgeting betraying how little she enjoyed sitting around as well. “That box of yours is going to disable the exterior cameras and alarms, plus break off their communication, right? So does that mean that, even if we miss a few guards, they can’t call for capes?”

“With a weaker security system, yes. But this is Level Three,” Hephaestus told her. “The line to the AHC is separate, and any attempt to tamper with it sets off a call. On the upside, it’s not automatic. The capes don’t want to come out every time a squirrel trips an exterior alarm. A guard has to activate it manually.”

They had, in truth, already gone over most of this; they were talking now simply for the sake of talking, as it let them focus on something other than the fear about whether their crime would even get off the ground. It was a distraction, nothing more, which was why neither was bothered when Pest Control opened his eyes and interrupted them.

“Glyph just killed my fly. Time to head out.”

No one hesitated or debated; there would be no point to it. Either Glyph had succeeded or he simply believed he had. Whichever was true didn’t change their next step. This was the only way to move forward. They stepped out of the shack one by one, with Hephaestus flipping on her sound dampener for the trek across the concrete parking lot. Her fuel cells were fine for the moment, and assuming things went smoothly, there would be no need to drain them. Still, she kept an eye on their levels, readying to juice them up if they dipped below eighty percent. This wasn’t the night to take pointless risks.

When they arrived at the shadow-covered expanse of the museum’s front entrance, Glyph was waiting for them, wiping the rune from his hand and erasing his shimmery cloaking. Behind him, a new rune glowed on the door, though it lacked the vibrancy they’d come to associate with an active casting. “Got the box hooked in to the electrical system just like you said,”



he announced. “And I’ve got the guard spell ready to go, just needs one more piece added.”

The knot of tension in Hephaestus’s gut tightened. While the waiting had been her least favorite part of the plan, this was unquestionably the most dangerous. Here everything teetered on a precipice. Glyph would use a spell that was supposed to put every person inside the building at that moment into a harmless slumber. Unfortunately, people with strong enough minds and forceful wills could often shake off the effects of mental magic, which left the possibility that some of the guards would manage to stay awake. All it took was one to trip the big alarm and draw the capes. If that happened, they’d be lucky to escape, let alone finish the job. Making things more difficult, none of them could go inside until after the spell was cast, lest they be caught in it and knocked off their guard as well.

“Let me get my wasps,” Pest Control said. A small swarm of unnatural creatures, wasps the size of small hamsters with strange purple stingers, manifested around him. Their hope was that his insects wouldn’t be impacted by magic crafted for humans, but just in case, he was keeping his attackers nearby. Worst case scenario, he hoped to at least see which guards were fighting off the trance before he lost his fly eyes in the sky.

While Pest Control gathered his troops, Hephaestus checked the front door. Sure enough, her device had triggered enough false readings to make the security system think it was daytime, thus deactivating most of the alarms and locks. The cameras had been trickier, especially since they were integrated with the electrical system, but with a little ingenuity and a lot of experimental magnetic bursts, she’d made it work. They only had a half an hour, though; after that, the device was set to melt itself into slag. No evidence left to examine or trace.

At least unlocking the door meant they were one hurdle down. Once Glyph triggered the spell, it would be up to Pest Control and her to pick off any straggling guards. Ideally, the ones who weren’t immediately brought down would think they were suffering nothing more than a wave of sleepiness, but these weren’t exactly doddering members of the Mayberry police force. With this much money to protect, the museum had hired people who were smart and tough. Just hopefully not too many of them.

“I’m good,” Pest Control announced. In addition to his wasps, he’d also gathered a fresh swarm of flies to serve as replacements if his current batch took an unexpected nap. “Hephaestus, I’ll give you starting locations before we head in then let you know if I find any others.”

“Quick and quiet, that’s the name of the game,” Hephaestus replied. She turned her helmet toward Glyph to catch his attention. “We’re ready whenever you are.”

Fingers once again glowing, Glyph turned to the waiting symbol and made a final line near the center. The rune burst into light. Each of them could feel the wave of power that washed off of it and cascaded through the building even as the symbol itself began to fade into nothingness.

“Guards are going down,” Pest Control announced, eyes closed. A small bead of sweat ran down his creased forehead, and his hands were clenched tightly into fists. “I’m trying to keep my flies up, but they’re starting to drop too. So far so good, though. We’re getting... shit, one just shook it off. Now another. Another. Fuck, we’ve got at least three still up, and one looks suspicious. We have to move!”

Without a moment’s pause, Hephaestus threw open the door and burst into the museum’s lobby, her heavy footsteps thankfully silenced as she pounded down across the tile floor. Pest Control was hot on her heels, the distinctive sound of buzzing filling the air as his minions spread out and raced through the air to their targets.

“Hephaestus, can you make it to the Egyptian wing?” Pest Control’s voice crackled through the comms despite their proximity. “That’s where the suspicious guard is, and I don’t think my bugs are fast enough.”

“On it.” She turned on her heel and bolted down a hallway to the right. Their team knew the museum’s layout backwards and forwards; it was something she’d insisted on during the planning phase. Unfortunately, that meant she knew how far of a run it would be to the Egyptian wing, which wouldn’t have been worrying if the guard office weren’t on the way. If she didn’t make it in time, the guard would sound the alarm and the capes would come.

Which just meant that Hephaestus had to make damn sure she wasn't too late.

\* \* \*

The placid boredom of the monitoring room was long gone. Hurried reports and frantic calls followed one another so quickly that sentences blurred together into one chaotic cloud that hung heavily over the employees' heads. Just as Stalwart Iron had predicted, the lull of the afternoon had given way to a sudden uptick in disasters that demanded superhero attention.

"Got a subway car stalled on the tracks," came a voice from the crowd. "No chance of injury, but the rerouting system is busted, which means that until we get in there, every other car is stuck behind it, leaving hundreds trapped."

"Send in Cresscriss," Apollo ordered. "He's got that alien tech that turns things weightless. Should make the car easy to pull out."

"Small fire in an abandoned warehouse district that could spread to populated areas if left unchecked," said another one of the operators.

"Flameingo and Aqua Bomb should have finished up the forest fire by now, get them over to the warehouses as soon as they're done." Apollo stepped away from the chaos for a moment, allowing the operators to handle the smaller incidents as he made his way over to the sole terminal staffed by another superhero.

Stalwart Iron wasn't snapping off orders or yelling at the operators; in fact, he wasn't saying anything at all. He merely watched his three screens silently, going over every report and dispatch as it came in with the single-minded focus that only a mechanical brain could manage. Apollo leaned down, ostensibly to stare at the screens, though they were little more than gibberish to him. In reality, he simply wanted to speak without others overhearing the conversation. None of the mundanes knew about the guild, and Apollo saw no reason to change that. Hell, he even kept actual members of the AHC on a need-to-know basis. The tolerance of criminals was not something he considered a point of pride for the Alliance.

“Find anything?”

“Nothing aside from the same bombardment that’s hitting everyone else’s screen,” Stalwart Iron replied. “But I’m trying to ignore that as best I can. If this is organized chaos, then anything we’re seeing is something they want us to look at, which means it serves their purposes. We have to look where they aren’t guiding our eyes.” He paused, checking the screens over once more, then began to type so quickly that Apollo feared his keyboard might break. “That gives me an idea. I’ve been trying to see a pattern in all this, but what I should be looking for is the absence of one.”

A few more clacks on the keyboard, and Stalwart Iron pulled up a new screen, this one a map that Apollo recognized well. “Why am I looking at Dash City?”

“Because it’s one of the only major metropolitan areas that *isn’t* seeing a huge upswing in crime and destruction tonight,” Stalwart Iron explained. “Everything we’re working with is still theoretical, but if we assume there is agency to these incidents, wouldn’t it stand to reason they would keep their actual target as clear of superheroes as possible?”

“It does make sense,” Apollo agreed. “But even if you’re right, Dash City is a big place, with a lot of places worth robbing. We have no idea when or where they’ll strike. Can we still find them?”

“Let me do some digging, sir. If they’re out there, I’ll uncover them.” Stalwart Iron went back to his screen, and Apollo walked away to let him work. If anyone could uncover the guild’s target, it would be Stalwart Iron. Once that happened, it was just a matter of sending out the new team and making sure the press was on standby.

Really, Apollo’s only regret was that he wouldn’t be able to see the looks on the older guild members’ faces as their entire new crop of criminals was simultaneously wiped out.

## Chapter 65

Hephaestus barreled through the “Hometown Heroes” section of the museum, darting past exhibits dedicated to the capes from Dash City like Combust, Baron Peppermint, and Dapper Doll. She hurdled over a stone bench, meta-suit giving her speed and strength that would have been impossible on her own. Even with the boosts, she was still cutting it close, which was why she’d decided to take a risk. If she’d correctly predicted the guard’s moves, he would try and reach the office to sound the alarm as soon as possible. If he’d taken the far route to investigate things further, then she would miss him completely. It was a big gamble, but there were no riskless choices available to her. That was what it meant to be a villain.

As she whipped around a corner, her heart sank. By her estimates, the guard should have at least made it to this hall by now. If it was empty, that meant she’d made the wrong choice. Hopeless as it seemed, she flicked over to her thermal cameras just to be sure. Her sinking heart leapt up to her throat. There he was, tucked carefully behind a nearby wall, hands held in a position that left no doubt he’d drawn his gun. But the suit’s silencers were still functional. How had he known she was coming?

Hephaestus spared a quick glance backward. Only then did she notice that her foot had clipped the edge of the bench, sending a spray of small concrete chunks across the floor. She hadn’t heard it over her own panting, but for someone moving carefully and listening well, there was no doubt the noise would be a beacon of approach.

So, he knew someone was coming, but probably not where she was. That would only last until he peeked around the corner, at which point bullets would no doubt begin to fly. Aside from alerting every other conscious guard that something was up, there was also the chance that a good shot would damage her suit; she hadn’t had time to adequately test its durability. She needed to stop him before he got off a single bullet.

Hephaestus began to run once more. For just this first moment, she knew where he was and he couldn’t track her. If she was fast enough, there

was a chance she could still take him by surprise.

Quick as she was, Hephaestus was still a few seconds short of catching the guard completely unaware. He spun around the corner, gun raised at the ready, just as she arrived. For a fleeting second, complete shock overtook him as he watched a metal person racing toward him at full speed. Then his eyes narrowed, and he raised the gun a few inches.

With no time to think, Hephaestus moved on pure instinct. Her right hand closed around the muzzle of the gun just as the first shot went off, and her left fired a series of small darts into the guard's chest. Resistant as his mind might have been to magic, it didn't have the same immunity to chemicals, and within seconds he was slipping gently to the floor. Hephaestus lowered him carefully, right hand still covering the gun, until he was safely resting on the tile. Only then did she pull back her gauntlet to survey the damage.

On the upside, the sound dampeners had managed to suppress the gun's roar and her gauntlet had successfully protected her hand. On the downside, however, the palm of the gauntlet was wrecked. The ray that concentrated thermal energy, the one she'd first shown Ivan and Xelas a prototype of, was useless. Without the focal point for release, it couldn't be trusted. Granted, she wasn't supposed to need it in a simple robbery, but she'd sure felt a lot better knowing it was there.

Flexing her fingers, she noted that the glove's responsiveness was also hindered. She could still use the hand for punching and other blunt-work, but anything delicate was off the table. That could be a problem, because she still had quite a bit of security hacking left to do before the night was done.

"Hephaestus." Pest Control's whispered voice crackled in her ear. "I've neutralized my guards, and I can't see any others. Were you able to subdue yours?"

"Yeah, I got him," Hephaestus confirmed. "He's safe and sound and will sleep until halfway through tomorrow morning."

"Glad to hear it. Glyph and Bahamut, that means you're both clear to enter. First phase of our infiltration is complete," Pest Control

announced.

One down, two to go. Hephaestus tested her gauntlet one more time then hurried off to meet the others at the lobby, a slight spring in her step. Busted ray aside, that first part had gone pretty smoothly, and that was the riskiest part. From here on, so long as they stayed smart and careful, they shouldn't have any more serious hurdles to clear.

\* \* \*

Donald was doing his best to hide his nerves, but it was a losing battle. The costume that had been designed for him—a reinforced dark silver number with electric blue highlights—felt natural despite its weight. After all, the garment and all its doubles hanging in his closet had been made specifically for him. Ren stood nearby, his own outfit more like gladiator armor, sections strapped on to offer protection while not restricting movement. These outfits should have made him feel like they were official, real superheroes waiting on their orders to go do genuine good work. Instead, he felt like a child wearing a Halloween costume, just waiting to be called out on his falsehood. Plus, his stomach was churning so much Donald feared he might vomit on the new outfit before it ever saw the light of day.

“You okay? Your face is a little green.” The brunette woman next to him, real name Irene and code name Cold Shoulder, stared at him from under her own icy blue-and-white mask. Donald hadn't been given anything to cover his head, as he was already known and would spend most of his fighting time in some sort of armor anyway. Apollo said it would better develop his name as a brand to stay recognizable, at least when out of combat.

“I'll be okay, just kind of nervous,” Donald admitted. “Seems like things are pretty crazy out there.”

“Why are you nervous? You've actually had real fights already. Two of them, in fact. I'm the rookie.” Irene had been added to “his and Ren's team” (Apollo's choice of words, not Donald's) earlier in the week. Ostensibly, it was to even out their lineup, as Donald was primarily good at ranged combat and Ren only fought in melee. Irene could take either position to back them up as needed. Unfortunately, all of that was

theoretical as she'd never gotten the chance to test her powers outside a training ground.

"To be honest, it's the waiting that's getting to me," Donald admitted. He looked around the sparse room they were in, stocked only with water, sodas, and energy bars. It was where they'd been instructed to wait until their deployment orders came, and with every passing minute, it felt more and more like some gray-carpeted prison cell. "The other times I fought, there wasn't really a chance to think about it. I just sort of got thrown into battle. Criminals broke into my office, a monster appeared at the club we were at, stuff just happened. This is the first time I've had to sit around and contemplate what's coming."

"None of us knows what's coming," Ren said. He'd been pacing the room; his own tension wasn't suited to being bottled up while sitting around. "It might be simple rescue work. Lifting beams, clearing rubble, moving people to safety. We've already debuted, so there's no need for us to put on any sort of show."

"Only some of us have debuted," Irene muttered, crossing her arms as she looked away. Donald and Ren exchanged a brief, uncomfortable look. Neither of them was so dense that they hadn't realized Apollo seemed to favor them over the other candidates, but it wasn't until Irene was brought on board that they started to see how big the gap was. None of the others were getting personal coaching sessions, or hand-picked code names, or high-level consulting. The only reason Irene was ready to go in the first place was that once Apollo had chosen her to join them, he'd fast-tracked her through all the setup processes so she'd be prepared.

"I'm sure that whatever Apollo sends us out to do, it will be the right assignment," Donald said. "Both for you to get your name out there, and for us to do our part in keeping the world safe. He hasn't steered us wrong yet."

"If it's another weird rhino-monster, I just hope this time I can get a few licks in." Ren flashed Donald a smile that, while technically more animal than human, still managed to convey a sense of friendship. At least, it did for Donald. From the way Irene stiffened up next to him, she might only have gotten the surface appearance of a monster bearing its fangs.



“You’ll have to move quickly,” Donald replied. He gently patted the computer on his wrist, inside of which were dozens of items available at a touch. “I’ve been leveling up these bad boys all week. This time, I could get it in one shot.”

“Big talk, but let’s see how big those shots are,” Ren said.

“Just stay clear when I get going. I doubt even you want to try and shrug off one of these blasts.”

“That goes for both of you on my front,” Irene said. “I’m a good shot but not a great one, and I’ve always been a fan of the ‘spray and pray’ philosophy on ranged combat.”

“Don’t worry, Ren’s pretty quick when he needs to be,” Donald assured her. “And if I’m in your field of targets, then things have already gone really freaking wrong.”

“Freaking?” Ren asked, lifting a furry eyebrow.

Donald shrugged. “We’re supposed to be superheroes, you know? I figured I’d try to get in the habit of not cursing while I was in costume.”

“Well, shut down the papers. We’ve got another Lodestar on our hands, folks!” Though Irene’s words were snippy, there was humor in them, which put Donald’s stomach at ease. The more they could come together as a team, the better a chance they stood once they finally had to leave this room.

\* \* \*

Art, aside from being a risky fiscal investment and a difficult market to predict, was also a thief’s best friend. Jewels had only as much inherent value as one gave them, which was technically true for all things but always seemed a bit truer when dealing with shiny rocks. Pottery and sculpture, priceless though they could be, were also a pain in the ass to transport and lost nearly all value with the slightest scratch or ding. Fossils and prehistoric relics were often too cumbersome to carry and had a black market audience limited to the rich with odd tastes and mad scientists trying to clone extinct species.

But the paintings of masters respected through the ages, those were nearly as good as stealing cash. Better, in fact, because a painting worth hundreds of thousands of dollars could be carefully rolled into a tube, whereas carrying that much in physical currency would get very tiring very quickly. Plus, there was always a market for the classics thanks to an abundance of wealthy people who would happily hide away such treasures for their own enjoyment. Unlike jewels, which really only held worth when they could be shown off, a painting was something that could be appreciated in secret and therefore its high price tag was justified.

The Dash City Museum knew all of this, of course, which was why the truly priceless pieces were under so much security that even a poorly aimed, particularly forceful sneeze would send a dozen automated security measures into effect. The museum had spared no expense, protecting paintings that would fetch millions of dollars on the black market with an almost equally costly system designed to stop all but the most powerful criminals. And *that* was why the four villains clustered together in the main wing of the “Famous Painters through the Ages” section weren’t so much as even glancing at those priceless artworks.

“Okay, I’ve got my remote system access set up,” Hephaestus announced at last, looking up from the small tablet she’d produced from one of her suit’s dozens of compartments. “The USB will melt once we’re done, which means we don’t need to go back for it. As soon as I try to trick the system, we’re back on the clock.”

“I really hope you pull this off,” Pest Control said. He’d taken the large tubular holster off his back and laid it on the ground. Inside were four smaller plastic tubes, though these lacked the strap to wrap around someone’s chest. “Our Plan B here is really shitty.”

“Speak for yourself. I think I can cut them out faster than she can hack them free,” Bahamut replied. Currently, she was a green dragon who lumbered over them, ready for the event that the hacking plan failed and they had to finish things off with a smash and grab. It was far from ideal, as such a tactic would alert the authorities, leave evidence, and perhaps get them pursued, but it was much better than going back to the guild empty-handed.

“It should work,” Hephaestus said, though whether she was trying to convince herself or her team was up for debate. “These displays sometimes get changed out, so the system has releases built in for when that happens. Now, the really high-end stuff requires, like, ten layers of verification, but they move around these lesser exhibits all the time as new pieces come in. I *should* be able to dupe the system.”

Hephaestus looked up from her tablet, waiting for more questions or comments, only to realize that everyone was staring back at her. There was nothing else to say unless she wanted to change the plan. She didn’t, not only because working her magic with her left hand had been a pain in the ass, but rather because she didn’t have a better one to offer up. It was all on her. If she outsmarted the system, they got a nice payday. If she’d failed to account for something or the security was better than her trickery, things were about to get really hectic, really fast.

All worrying would do was waste their precious time, though. Hephaestus clicked the startup sequence for her program, began to say a prayer, and then realized that stealing probably wasn’t the sort of thing one was supposed to turn to the heavens for help with.

She held her breath instead as the sequences played out on her screen. Her mind flashed back to that night at Indigo Technologies when she’d let her arrogance lead her right into an inescapable trap. She’d worked so hard and come so far since then, but it was always possible she’d made another mistake. This time, if she failed, the alarm would trip and her villainy would be over before it had really begun. She waited to hear the telltale screech of high-pitched sirens screaming through the air, all but ruining their chances of—

*Whoosh.*

The airlock on one of the nearest paintings, a carefully-chosen target selected for its recent upswing in value thanks to shifting tastes in the art world, released loudly as the frame pulled slightly away from the canvas. Glyph didn’t hesitate, hurrying over and carefully slipping the artwork from under its case. He rolled it delicately as he walked, placing it into one of the four smaller tubes that Pest Control had already prepared, then stowing that in the larger transport tube.

By the time he was done, the second painting's airlock had released, and Pest Control was already on it. Bahamut sat nearby, ready to act if this went awry, but with every passing second, it was beginning to seem like they wouldn't need Plan B after all.

Hephaestus breathed a long sigh of relief as the third airlock released. Three down, one to go, and then phase two would be complete.

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## Chapter 66

“Apollo, there’s something you need to see.” Stalwart Iron wasn’t frantic. He didn’t raise his voice. In fact, he made no effort to seem like he was showing the glowing superhero anything more than a routine bit of data that might warrant his attention. This, this was why Apollo liked dealing with the electronic people of the world; they were so much more dependable than the emotional human ones.

“Sure thing.” Apollo made his way over slowly, then leaned down to look at the screens in front of Stalwart Iron once more. “What have you got for me?”

“Well, since narrowing down the target to Dash City, I’ve been monitoring the security of everywhere that might prove a lucrative target,” Stalwart Iron explained. “But on top of that I’ve also been checking on the subroutines and basic system functions to see if I caught anything out of the ordinary. Two minutes ago, I believe that effort paid off. Despite the late hour, it seems someone at the Dash City Museum has just authorized the changing out of four paintings from their protective cases.”

“Someone hacked a Level Three system? That’s impressive,” Apollo said, quickly realizing the implication.

“Yes and no. Though the overall system is rated at three, certain components are more extensive than others,” Stalwart Iron explained. “The paintings in question are considered less valuable and therefore don’t have as many layers of protection as the ones with a larger monetary or cultural value.”

“I see, so they didn’t go for one big score. They decided to make it up in volume.” Apollo’s grin was pearly white and off-putting in its ferocity, the sort of expression he would never have allowed the cameras to catch a glimpse of. “Smarter than I was expecting. Good. They’ll make for worthwhile opponents. Have Bridge stop whatever she’s doing and immediately prepare for transport. Also, wait five minutes after I leave, and

then tip off the Dash City media that a robbery in progress has just been stopped by superheroes from the AHC.”

“Can do,” Stalwart Iron replied. “Countdown will begin as soon as you exit the room.”

“Well then, fire it up, because I’m off to go fetch our rookies,” Apollo said. “I think it’s time we reminded that guild that they’re nothing more than rats. Smash a few heads, and the rest will scurry back to the shadows.”

\* \* \*

“That’s all of them,” Pest Control announced, slipping the final tube into the larger container and closing the top. It let out a small puff of air as it sealed, supposedly protecting all contents inside from heat, water, air, and other possible corruptions. The tube had cost them the last of their resource money, but all had agreed it was a worthwhile purchase, just in case things went awry.

“Then phase two is done,” Hephaestus announced. “With acquisition finished, all that leaves is escape. I’m not picking up anything on the police bands about the museum, so hopefully no one knows we’re here.”

“Still, better not to take any risks.” Bahamut, now back to being human-sized, reached into her costume and pulled out the communicator Tunnel Vision had provided. “Let’s call our ride home and get out of here.”

“Not quite that easy,” Glyph said. “Remember, we can only call from secure locations, places where there’s no chance of anything being seen through the portal. We took out a lot of cameras, but in a place like this, there’s no way to be totally sure we got everything. Tunnel Vision even told us not to try it in the museum.”

“He’s right,” Hephaestus agreed. “Our best bet is probably the abandoned ice cream stand. Obviously it’s secure enough or they wouldn’t have been okay with using it for our drop off.”

Pest Control finished slipping the tube over his shoulder and strapping it firmly in place. “If that’s the case, then let’s get going. The

longer we stay here, the bigger the risk.”

“Send a few scouts ahead, just to be safe,” Bahamut instructed.

“Hephaestus said the cops weren’t coming,” Glyph pointed out.

“No, I said I couldn’t hear anything that said they were coming.” Hephaestus rose from her seat, putting away her tablet and doing a quick sweep around them. Nothing stood out, even switching across different camera modes, but assuming the readings were accurate, they were still temporary at best. “That’s not the same as *knowing* the cops aren’t coming. Let’s spare the extra minute to send a few bugs.”

“If you two think it’s worth the time, then okay.” Pest Control lifted his arms. A dozen mosquitoes appeared in the air above him, taking off through the nearest door and heading out into the parking lot. He stood like that for several moments before lowering his hands. “They don’t see anything out there. Near as I can tell, we’ve got nothing but empty parking spaces between us and freedom.”

Part of Hephaestus tried to think of more methods they could use to assure their safety, but she knew she was drifting into paranoia. If they stood around all night, afraid to act, then they really would get caught eventually. They’d done their best to scan the area, and just because things were going well didn’t mean some sudden horror was about to fall upon them.

Still... it wouldn’t hurt to be as cautious as possible.

“Pest Control, give the tube to Bahamut before we leave.”

“Mind if I ask why first?” Pest Control said, though he did begin unslinging it from his shoulder.

“If we’re just walking across a parking lot, then it doesn’t matter who carries it,” Hephaestus replied. “But if anything goes wrong, she’s the only one of us who can take to the skies. Bahamut can—and should—get immediately clear of any situation and call Tunnel Vision for transport home. As long as none of us gets caught, we’re all fine, but if anything happens to the loot...” She didn’t bother finishing that sentence; they were all keenly aware of what would happen if they failed their test.

“Can’t say I love the idea of you taking me out of a fight,” Bahamut grumbled as she donned the tube’s strap.

“Then let’s hope I’m being pointlessly paranoid and we’re in for a three-minute walk.” Even as she said it, Hephaestus had a feeling that wouldn’t be the case. There was no factual reason to suspect their job had been compromised, except that this wasn’t just a job. It was a test. And she couldn’t imagine they would be allowed to get off quite so easily as this.

“Everyone ready?” She looked at her fellow apprentices, noting that despite getting the all clear, each looked as though they were about to step into sheer chaos. Perhaps she wasn’t the only one who felt like things had gone a bit too smoothly. Good. Better they all went in with their nerves steeled and their eyes open. Even if it was just for a stroll across a parking lot.

\* \* \*

“Why isn’t there more room in this thing?” Cold Shoulder began to squirm once more until Medley put a clawed hand gently on her shoulder.

“Sorry. *Awesome Assassin Alliance* is meant to be two-player at most, so the Cloak of Rad Camouflage isn’t designed for three people.” Donald—Cyber Geek now that they were actually out in the field—sounded muffled through the helmet resting easily on his face. He’d grabbed the blaster and the blanket before armoring up since getting to his wrist display was a pain when it was covered by digitally-conjured protection.

“I still don’t get why we’re just waiting around.” Cold Shoulder wasn’t wiggling anymore, but her voice was loud enough to serve as warning to anyone who came near.

“Apollo said this gang doesn’t teleport out of secure locations,” Medley reminded her. “It’s part of their MO. So we wait, and when they come out, we take them by surprise.”

“Well, they seem to be taking their sweet—” Cold Shoulder’s voice fell silent as Cyber Geek squeezed her arm, gesturing to the figures emerging from the museum’s front entrance. Thankfully, the Cloak of Rad Camouflage only blocked visuals from one side—for them, it was like



peering through a still puddle. Everything could be seen, though the view was a bit wonky.

“Remember, our goals are to capture the criminals and secure the stolen merchandise, prioritized in that order,” Cyber Geek said, repeating Apollo’s instructions almost word for word. “I can draw their attention, but that’s a lot of gap to close for you two.”

“I can cover us as we approach,” Cold Shoulder offered. To both of their surprise, the easily-annoyed meta they’d gotten to know had completely slipped away. In her place was a woman who was all business. “In fact, I can pin them in, assuming none of them have abilities that let them cut through solid ice.”

“We’re going in blind, so just do what you can and hope for the best. Draw attention until Medley is in range, and then pick them off as he keeps them distracted. And remember: nobody dies, please.” Cyber Geek leaned forward, gripping the base of blanket and bringing his massive gun to the ready. “All right, in three, two, one: Go!”

\* \* \*

“Go!”

In that one lone syllable, Hephaestus heard all of her paranoid fears spring to life. Before she’d turned, before she’d caught sight of Medley charging toward them, before she could identify the unfamiliar woman in the blue-and-white outfit, before she could fully digest Donald clad in armor and pointing a giant gun at them—before she saw any of it—she knew they’d been caught in the act. But no sooner had the thought gone through her head than another came on its heels: being caught wasn’t the same thing as being captured. And just like that, her priorities shifted as she prepared to meet their new challenge head-on.

“Cover Bahamut, then get clear!” Hephaestus ordered. With a glance over her shoulder, she saw that her friend was already halfway through her shift into the white dragon. Behind her, Glyph was etching something hurriedly on her scaly back between her spread wings while Pest Control summoned wave after wave of wasps. Most were heading toward their attackers, but many stayed near Bahamut. Hephaestus didn’t know

exactly what Pest Control had in mind, but for the moment all she could do was trust him. As it stood, their chances were already slim. If they started second-guessing one another, all was as good as lost.

Hephaestus was trying to decide whether to intercept Medley's charge or try and get into a game of long-shots with Donald when a blast of icy energy struck near her foot and almost managed to freeze her in place. She jumped aside, but the cold continued to build. Soon it had formed a seven-foot high ice-wall that stretched outward, blocking Hephaestus from making a run to the museum's south. So, the blue-and-white lady was a meta with ice powers. She wasn't sure if that was ironic or not, given her own abilities, but she did know it annoyed the crap out of her. If the woman managed to freeze Bahamut or any of the other apprentices, they were all sunk; this meant Hephaestus needed to make sure she stayed the ice-gal's main target.

"Nice shot, Frosty! This time, why don't you actually try opening your fucking eyes when you aim." Hephaestus bolted right for the woman lining up another ice blast. To her left, Medley seemed to reorient, aiming for the target that was now narrowing the gap between them. That was unexpected but a stroke of luck. Medley was a heavy hitter, and with Bahamut in the air, they wouldn't have anyone that could stand up to him. If she used her meta-suit, she might be able to hold him off for a while. And if that failed, she was pretty sure he didn't have any way to catch living fire, although the same could not be said for the ice-woman.

"My name is Cold Shoulder!" Those words were the only warning Hephaestus got before a torrent of freezing energy came right at her. Honed reflexes augmented by carefully-crafted technology snapped into action, and Hephaestus leapt to the side just in time to avoid the massive chunk of ice that formed by her feet. While she readied for another blast, Cold Shoulder took her by surprise. Instead of a concentrated beam, she spread her arms and let out something like a pulse. Immediately, the entire parking lot began to ice over; Hephaestus only avoided slipping thanks to the weight of her suit and the traction of the metal boots on her feet.

"And I think that is just adorable." Damn. When this was over, she'd have to talk with Ivan about banter; somehow, she felt like she was really coming up short so far. Instead of trying to think of another one-liner,

Hephaestus took aim and fired more of the tranquilizing darts she'd used on the guard. If her luck held, she could knock out the biggest threat to their escape without causing any lasting damage.

Unfortunately, it seemed Cold Shoulder hadn't stepped onto the battlefield without some defensive plans of her own. She held up a single hand and a giant shield of ice materialized in front of her, easily stopping the darts. What was worse, the shield didn't vanish; it merely slid to the side as if it had no weight while Cold Shoulder fired off another round of freezing energy.

This time, Hephaestus couldn't get away with a simple hop. She had to throw herself to the ground in a tucked roll. Clear of the attack, she spun away and leapt back to her feet. It was a dangerous move that left her open to another shot—a shot which, oddly, didn't come. Only when Hephaestus was reoriented did she realize why, and in that moment, suddenly being caught by a freeze blast didn't seem so bad.

Cold Shoulder had conjured more ice—a lot more—only she'd called it up around herself. She stood encased in what looked to be a fifteen-foot tall humanoid construct made of ice, its frosty fists balled up and a dangerous glint in its wintry eye. If that weren't bad enough—and by Hephaestus's reckoning, it definitely was—Medley had finally arrived at Cold Shoulder's side. The mighty beast was dwarfed by her ice-construct armor, but he was still a good few feet taller than Hephaestus, even with the extra couple of inches from her armor.

This was bad. There were still a few tricks up her meta-suit's sleeves, but losing the main cannon in her right gauntlet had severely limited her options. Granted, she still wouldn't have been allowed to char a cape, but at least it would have left bluffing on the table. The only upside to this predicament was that if both Medley and Cold Shoulder were both focused on her, the others should be free to slip away easily.

The sound of Donald's—Cyber Geek's—blaster dispelled that notion swiftly from her mind and acted as some sort of trigger for Cold Shoulder and Medley as well. The two charged as a team. Hephaestus no longer had the luxury of worrying about the other apprentices. Her hands were full with just trying to stay alive.

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## Chapter 67

When the first shots came, Bahamut was sure they were sunk. She'd seen the kind of damage that gun could dish out firsthand, and while her green dragon-form might, *might* have been able to withstand a blast, her white dragon wasn't nearly as tough. Her eyes closed, and all she could feel was Glyph etching a second symbol onto her back as she waited for the end to come. Instead, she heard Pest Control let out a string of swears, along with the crackling sizzle of insects being burned up.

"Fucker! Those things hurt."

Hurt? The shots should be cooking right through them. Bahamut opened her scaly eyes. Rather than the giant beam that had torn through an otherworldly monster, Cyber Geek was pelting them with small blue bursts, most of which Pest Control's wall of flying bugs were absorbing.

"Why isn't he trying to kill us?" She didn't mean for the words to be spoken, but they still slipped out nonetheless. As Glyph finished drawing on her back, he spun around to answer.

"'Cause they're the good guys, duh. We're not a threat to anyone, we're not causing massive damage, and we haven't even shown aggression. It would look really bad if they just killed us in one go without even giving us the chance to surrender." Glyph reached over and patted the pair of symbols on her back, each letting out a pulse of energy as he did. "Now you've got some shielding. Once you slip out of sight, they shouldn't be able to track you. Get clear, turn back, and keep the paintings safe."

"Do you two have an exit plan?" Bahamut asked.

"Well, since Hephaestus is currently holding the attention of two of them, I'd say we'll use my bugs to give video-game boy the slip. Maybe Glyph has a symbol or two left as well," Pest Control offered. He was rematerializing the bugs as fast as he could, but Cyber Geek's endless shots were clearly tearing through them at a greater rate.

“With two on Bahamut, the most I can sustain is one more,” Glyph said. “But with the right timing, I might be able to pull something off.”

Bahamut took in the scene before her. Hephaestus was squaring off against a giant ice monster and Medley, neither of which looked to be pushovers. Cyber Geek had the team functionally pinned down with his blasts. It had made sense to give her the paintings inside the museum when this was all abstract, but now that things had gotten real, that wisdom was waning. Yes, if the paintings were damaged, then they were all sunk; however, the same could be said if any of them were captured. She was the group’s heavy hitter, and while Hephaestus might manage to slip away, things didn’t look as good for Pest Control and Glyph. Their first plan had been solid, but getting everyone out here meant they had to be willing to call audibles when it was needed. And that was exactly what Bahamut planned to do.

“Glyph, take the paintings from me, then pull off the shield magic. Pest Control, forget everything else: just keep churning out bugs. Keep us hidden, no matter what it takes.”

“You’re supposed to escape.” Pest Control spit the words out through gritted teeth as he narrowed his focus, conjuring more and more flying insects to fill the gaps where the shots had come in.

“Which will leave you both totally exposed. Don’t worry, I’ve got an idea,” Bahamut said. She was nearly back to her human-form, taking care to stay as concealed behind the cover of bugs as possible. She had a feeling that with no protection from her dragon magic, one of those shots might stun her long enough for this all to go off the rails. “Glyph! Your concealment magic, it lets you slip by people?”

“People who don’t know you’re there, and only if they’re distracted,” he explained. “It’s not invisibility.” Glyph was fastening the tube around his own chest as he spoke. While he might want more explanation of what the plan was, it was clear he also realized the path they’d been on would lead to failure.

“Perfect. Get it on yourself and Pest Control, then wait here under cover of the bugs,” she said. “I’m going to give you both the perfect

distraction. When that happens, all eyes will be on me, I promise. After that, run like hell to the ice cream stand and call Tunnel Vision.”

“The magic won’t work if you just step out from here,” Glyph warned her. “He’s aware of all three of us. I don’t think even you’d be tough enough to make it to him while taking fire from those energy shots.”

“Which is why I’m going back into the museum and slipping out a side exit,” Bahamut replied. “We’re already busted, so alarms don’t mean shit. Just seize the opportunity when it comes. You’ll only get one shot at this.”

“If you’re going to do it, then please hurry. This ain’t exactly a light jog.” Sweat glistened on Pest Control’s face, but the bugs were filling in the wall faster than Cyber Geek could fry them, albeit slowly. He wouldn’t be able to manage it for long; she had to make the most of her window while it was still open.

Without another word, Bahamut turned and dashed back into the museum, turning partially green and scaly as she moved. The less they could see of her true form, the better; she had a feeling any remaining security tapes were going to get the ever-loving shit examined out of them. Plus, dragon-strength let her run faster, and she was all too aware that she was racing a clock. Even if Pest Control and Glyph could hold out, there was still Hephaestus to worry about.

\* \* \*

The meta-suit, despite its appearance, had not been designed for melee combat. Certainly, the armoring offered an enhanced defense, and the servos were capable of delivering far more physical force than if it had been Tori doing the punching; however, the purpose of the meta-suit was to offer utility, defense, and mobility above all else. Plus a cannon, for bad situations, which Hephaestus was dearly wishing hadn’t been broken earlier in the night. To keep this up required her to continue pumping energy into the suit, so much and so hot her body was nearly insubstantial inside it. It was all she could do to keep up with the pair of capes trying to beat her down.

A flurry of icicles whizzed by. She dodged to the side, almost taking a punch from Medley as she fell into their trap. Her reactions were good—she hadn't survived as a criminal for as long as she'd managed without learning to brawl—but the simple truth of it was that Medley was a far better fighter than she. And while Cold Shoulder apparently couldn't do the freezing beams while encased in her construct, she could make the ice-suit grow incredibly sharp icicles, which she would then throw with enough force to dent the meta-suit.

In fact, the only reason Hephaestus hadn't gone down yet was that Medley and Cold Shoulder clearly had no practice fighting together. They kept stepping in the other's way, dodging around attacks meant for her, and just generally slowing one another down. One on one, either of them would have been a challenge. Medley certainly would have forced her to abandon the suit. But the sum of their parts was less than their individual strength, and Hephaestus capitalized on that weakness as much as she could.

Putting herself between them, she registered another icicle attack on her helmet's display and leapt aside, allowing the freezing projectiles to strike Medley's torso. They shattered on impact, doing no visible damage, though they did manage to distract him momentarily. Hephaestus took advantage of that moment by loading a fresh round of paralyzing darts into the gun on her left arm. Medley's hide was too thick for a shot to pierce, so Hephaestus charged the furry monster, catching him slightly by surprise. It was enough to get off one punch, which she drove into the side of his neck, tilting her wrist down so that the mouth of the gun struck his flesh. While this angle did far less damage than if she'd kept her fist angled properly, it did allow her to fire at the same time she hit. Hephaestus could see a trio of darts sticking out of his neck as she pulled away. They might not be embedded deep enough to deliver the chemicals, but it was as good as they were ever going to get. Hephaestus was feeling good about her gamble until a clawed hand whipped forward, snagging her retreating left arm and spinning her around.

"Gotcha," Medley growled, twisting the captured arm so that it forced Hephaestus to her knees. There was no danger of actually breaking bones since she was already on the verge of not having them, but the suit could only twist so many ways. Besides, this position had her back directly



to Medley, which sparked something of an idea. If she could just get the angle right, this might be the chance she was waiting for.

“I have a feeling you won’t go peacefully, even if I offer you the chance to surrender, but rules are rules. Give up now, get out of the suit, and you won’t be hurt. If you keep fighting, I can’t guarantee your safety.” Medley’s speech wasn’t slurred and his grip certainly wasn’t wavering, so it looked like the drugs either hadn’t made it in or didn’t have any effect. It had been a long shot in the first place; metas with such physical abilities usually weren’t susceptible to mere toxins.

Still, Hephaestus hadn’t given up yet. She leaned a little lower to the ground, stretching the suit’s arm as far as she could. This would only be a surprise once, and she needed the aim to be just right.

“All right, since you’re not getting out, I guess you want to do this the hard way. Cold Shoulder, ice him up,” Medley ordered. “We’ll get this guy out of his suit back in AHC headquarters.”

Well, that wasn’t good. Thanks to the suit’s cameras and display, Hephaestus could see Cold Shoulder’s ice construct parting. The giant took Cold Shoulder in its hand and gently set her down. The lady was powerful; Hephaestus had to give her that. She’d assumed Medley and Cyber Geek were the best that the AHC had in their rookies, but maybe they’d been keeping the really strong ones as a surprise. Either way, getting caught in one of those ice blocks would be bad. Hephaestus wasn’t sure how living fire would work against that sort of power and sure as shit wasn’t in a hurry to find out. But Medley was so quick, even if she got the angle right, he might dodge. What she needed was a distraction, just one moment where they weren’t focused on her.

Luck, fate, or whatever deity watched over villains was clearly listening to her thoughts. As Cold Shoulder raised her hands and prepared to attack, a dragon’s roar split the night, and suddenly Hephaestus was no longer the more attention-grabbing problem to deal with.

\* \* \*

The mood in the council chambers had shifted many times as the occupants watched the night’s crimes take place. Apprehension as they

watched the apprentices make the approach. Worry when some of the guards resisted Glyph's magic. Excitement as Pest Control and Hephaestus chased them down before they could sound an alarm. Relief when the paintings' frames opened and no security alarm sounded. And, of course, fear when the capes ambushed their rookies during the exit from the museum. Fear not for themselves or their organization, but for this newest crop of villains, who so many of them had personally invested in and who were now on the brink of being wiped out.

"How the hell did they find them?" Xelas snapped. "I was watching the system the whole time, and not one alarm went out."

"Perhaps someone noticed them sneaking in and called the police. Perhaps there were security measures even we were unaware of. Those are the risks and realities of a real job; nothing is certain and everything can be affected by chance." Doctor Mechaniacal watched patiently, a somber expression on his face as he gauged the actions of the apprentices.

Ivan knew that Wade took no joy in what they were witnessing, but the truth of the matter was that sometimes these things did happen. Granted, it usually wasn't on one's first job with no backup or more experienced guild members to help. The whole coincidence struck Ivan as just a touch suspicious, though he couldn't imagine how even Wade could have convinced the AHC to send their newest recruits out to stop the crime.

"At least they're being smart," Thuggernaut said, half-whispering to Ivan as they watched the scene play out in front of them. "The focus is obviously on getting away, just like they were taught. Escape over engagement."

"Easy for you to say, your apprentice isn't trying to fight two capes at once," Ivan replied. On-screen, Hephaestus took a swing at Medley, connecting, but getting her arm snared in the process. "Badly, I might add."

"She's putting the group first, drawing attention so the others can sneak away." Thuggernaut looked at the older villain carefully, remembering the man with the glowing eyes who had once terrorized entire battalions of capes. "If memory serves, you used to do the same. You'd fight capes ten at a time if you were trying to help your friends get away."

“True, but there are two very important differences between the old me and the current Hephaestus,” Ivan said. “One, I was much stronger than she is, which is why I could manage fights like that. And two, I was much dumber than she, which is why I’d expect to see a little more strategy out of my apprentice.”

“She’s got two of the capes paying attention solely to her, and even if they cuff the suit, she can still slip away,” Thuggernaut pointed out. “It’s a pretty good plan for the spur of the moment. Hopefully the other three can find their own way to withdraw. I am proud of them for not trying to do anything stupid like—”

That was when the roar echoed through the room’s speakers, drawing all attention to a previously boring part of the screen and simultaneously leaving Thuggernaut a few shades paler. He opened and closed his mouth several times, but no words came out. Ivan patted the large man gently on the shoulder.

“On the plus side,” Ivan said, his voice surprisingly gentle, “at least no one can claim our apprentices are cowards.”

Thuggernaut had no reply; he merely watched the screen in mute shock as chaos unfolded before him.

## Chapter 68

The bug thing was weird. Maybe a guy who pulled items out of video games didn't have a lot of room to judge, but it didn't stop Cyber Geek from getting the willies as he gunned down wave after wave of the things. True, he could have easily cut through them if he'd switched the blaster's mode to something more deadly; however, that came with the very real possibility of also carving up the meta creating them. Robbing a museum was kind of a dick move, sure, but it didn't seem like the sort of thing someone should get killed for. Especially when they weren't even using the bugs to attack, but rather as a makeshift, albeit creepy, shield.

For a moment, he'd considered switching targets to try helping Medley and Cold Shoulder, though one look at the fracas that was their fight told him he wasn't nearly a good enough shot to hit the dude in the metal suit without potentially clipping his friends. Instead, he focused on keeping the other metas pinned down. It freed up his team to handle the more aggressive threat without unnecessarily elevating the situation. He had plenty of stunning blasts to send out, and the bug-wall was getting thinner and thinner the longer they had their standoff.

Really, the only thing bothering Cyber Geek was that he didn't have a good count of how many metas they were fighting. Metal-suit was one and bug-person was another. He thought he'd seen something white and scaly in the gaps between bugs, but it had vanished and at this range, he didn't completely trust his eyes. There were at least two people pinned behind the insects, maybe three, and it was that maybe that worried him. This was a big outing; the last thing they wanted to do was let one of the criminals slip away because he couldn't count.

Cyber Geek was so focused on trying to peek through the bug curtain as he shot it apart that he never noticed the creature approaching him until a pair of strong claws closed around his shoulders. In his defense, though, how was he supposed to know he needed to keep an eye on the sky? That mistake was made quickly apparent as the powerful beating of

wings filled his ears, followed by a triumphant roar as a massive creature plucked him skyward.

Panic overwhelmed him, the sight of the shrinking ground triggering the primal part of his brain that knew it was not a creature meant for the heavens. Below him, Medley and Cold Shoulder both looked toward the roar, jaws hanging open as they got a good look at whatever flying thing had him gripped in its claws. Cyber Geek struggled to reorient himself, perhaps even angle his gun upward to take a shot at the creature, but holding the blaster in both arms for stability meant the grip pinning his arms and shoulders also locked the aim in place. As much strength as the armor added, it was clearly no match for the monster holding him. With every passing second, the ground drew further away.

He heard something, a scream like a wounded beast. He tried to check on Medley, but he was no longer facing the parking lot, and the *Blaster Brahs* helmet left a lot to be desired in terms of maneuverability.

“Can you survive a fall in that tin can?” If being snatched from the ground had shocked Cyber Geek, hearing the creature that had done it speak to him left him completely flummoxed. He didn’t even know if he could respond, let alone what his response would be, until the monster shook him from side to side, snapping him out of his bewilderment.

“Are you trying to scare me? Because I won’t give up that easy.” It was the first thing that came to mind, the sort of indomitable dialogue he’d always imagined the greats like Lodestar would deliver in dire situations.

The creature snorted, an altogether terrifying noise, and then let out something that sounded almost like laughter. “I’m not threatening you. I’m doing the opposite. I can’t fly around with you all night, but I also don’t want to get caught. I need to get out of here, and I’d prefer not to kill you in the process.”

“But you’re a criminal,” Cyber Geek protested. Between the height and the strangeness of what was happening, he could hardly be blamed for getting more confused by the second.

“I robbed a museum. That’s a far cry from murder. Just because I’m willing to break one law doesn’t mean I’ll ignore them all. Now, are you

able to survive the fall or not? You're heavier than you look."

Cyber Geek swallowed hard and looked down at the ground, trying to gauge how high up they were. He'd leveled up the suit a good bit since his last fight, but there were still limits to what it could absorb. Even in the game, falling from too high cost a life, and he didn't have any extra to spare, a thought that opened up a whole new path of questions he might need to explore. But that would come later; for now, he needed to survive the next five minutes.

"Not like... *any* fall. But if you get within a hundred feet or so, I should be fine." In truth, he'd be more than fine from that height. If he were quick enough, he might even be able to turn on his thrusters and get off one last shot at the monster. With his thumb, he clicked a small dial on the back of the blaster, choosing a new mode. Killing would be wrong, especially when the criminal was going out of its way to spare his life, but a potent electrical blast might stun it long enough to capture.

The wings stopped beating, and Cyber Geek realized they were dropping rapidly. He'd never been part of a dive from a firsthand view, but that seemed like a good guess as to what was happening. The ground, nowhere near the museum anymore, was racing up at him so quickly that his stomach felt like it was rising into his throat.

"Get braced, I'm dropping on three," the monster warned him.

"But we're still so high!" There was no way they were at hundred feet yet, at least gauging from the treetops surrounding them.

"Trust me, I've calculated this out. Okay, one—"

And just like that, the claws released him, sending Cyber Geek tumbling unprepared through the air. He cursed himself for believing the count—obviously the creature knew he might counterattack and had wanted to catch him unprepared. Spinning through the air, he marshaled his senses and strove to focus. There, soaring away from him at a rapid pace, was the sole speck of white amid a dark sky.

Cyber Geek raised his gun and took careful aim. It wasn't going to be quite that easy. He wouldn't let it be.

\* \* \*

Hephaestus didn't hesitate. As soon as she realized what Bahamut had done and how fucking balls-out insane as it was, she seized the opportunity. While she hadn't quite gotten her meta-suit airborne, she had planned on the eventual possibility, and that included building in a vent and thruster system. Leaning as far forward as she could, Hephaestus flipped her thrusters on, sending focused jets of flame out from the openings on her back. They had almost no range, but the drawback to holding someone in an arm lock was that it meant standing very, very close to them. So close, in fact, that the flames from her thrusters caught Medley's fur, which was, thankfully, not fireproof.

The creature let out a howl of pain as it began to roast, and Hephaestus's left arm was suddenly free once more. She leapt to the side, getting out of Cold Shoulder's direct aim before the woman with ice powers could figure out what was going on. Between Cyber Geek being spirited into the sky and Medley suddenly turning into a fireworks display, it was no wonder Cold Shoulder needed a moment to figure out what was happening.

That moment was all Hephaestus needed as she unloaded the last of her paralyzing darts into Cold Shoulder's torso. Powerful as she was, if caught without her ice-shields, she was just as vulnerable as anyone else. With little more than a flutter of her eyelashes, Cold Shoulder began to fall headfirst toward the concrete. Moving solely on reflex, Hephaestus darted forward, catching Cold Shoulder before her head could strike and setting her body the rest of the way down. It was a small gesture that cost her little more than a few seconds of her time.

Unfortunately, those seconds turned out to be pretty crucial.

"That *hurt*." Medley's voice, always something of a growl, had the hint of animalistic danger in it that he worked so hard to keep at bay. He was staring at her, smoke still trailing from the edges of his singed fur. The ground was sooty and stained where he'd rolled the fire out, like someone had launched a half-dozen bottle rockets on its surface.

One down, one to go. Sadly, this was the tougher of the two, and Hephaestus was beginning to run dry on tricks. She racked her brain to

think of a plan, but Medley already had one. The words had no sooner left his mouth than he attacked.

And this time, Cold Shoulder wasn't around to slow him down.

\* \* \*

Pest Control and Glyph didn't need any encouragement to move as they watched Bahamut soar down from the sky and pluck up Cyber Geek like a children's toy. With only a single glance between them—one meant more to convey a general sense of “Holy shit!” than the need to make sure the other was running—they took off in a dead sprint for the abandoned ice cream shack. As they moved, each kept waiting for the sound of being caught, either in a yell from Medley or a shot from the ice-wielding meta whose name they'd been too far away to hear.

The yell did come, though it was more of a scream. One look told them that it had nothing to do with them being spotted. Medley was lit up like a fireworks stand with poor fire safety rules, and Hephaestus was already advancing on her other foe. With all three capes' attention well-managed, the escaping duo finished their run, bolting into the shack and shutting the door. Glyph yanked out his remote with the lone button that Tunnel Vision had provided and jammed his thumb down on it so hard that, for a moment, the plastic got wedged into the device.

“Nothing's happening,” Pest Control whispered, peering carefully through the shack's window just in time to watch Hephaestus fire a barrage of darts at the cape in blue and white.

“They said there would be a delay.” Though Glyph tried to remain calm, it was all he could do not to vomit as he counted the seconds in his head. If he reached ten and the doorway through space hadn't opened, he had no idea what they would do. Mercifully, just as he hit nine, the back wall of the shack vanished. Sanctum could be seen only steps away. All he had to do was move. But this time, he did hesitate, for just a moment.

“Is Hephaestus okay?” Glyph asked. They did need the whole team to make it, after all.



“Okay? She’s got Medley rolling on the ground in pain and just knocked that other gal clean out.” Pest Control left the window, slapped Glyph on the shoulder, and stepped through the portal. “She’s doing a damn sight better than okay. Let’s just hope Bahamut managed to get away clean as well.”

Relieved, for purely tactical reasons of course, Glyph followed Pest Control into Sanctum. He turned around to look back in the shack, waiting for Hephaestus to appear and follow them, but suddenly all he was looking at was a smooth metal wall.

“We do not leave open windows,” the male half of Tunnel Vision explained. “The others may call when they are secure.”

“Well, Hephaestus should be here in a few seconds,” Pest Control told them.

After the first minute of waiting, Glyph’s stomach began to tighten in fear. By the tenth, it was all he could do to keep from vomiting. Something had gone wrong, and now they didn’t even have the option of helping out.

Their futures were completely in the hands of Hephaestus and Bahamut.

\* \* \*

In Cyber Geek’s visor, the white creature (was it a freaking dragon?) lit up as his targeting system locked. Despite spinning through the air and tumbling toward the ground, he’d lined up his shot; now that the gun was locked, there was no way he’d miss. He steadied his aim and began to gently squeeze on the blaster’s heavy trigger.

Unfortunately, the downside to focusing solely on his target was that Cyber Geek had ignored his other surroundings. The folly in that strategy became abundantly clear as he smashed back-first into a tree, depleting a healthy amount of his shields and killing his momentum entirely. He began to fall straight down, clipping heavy branches along the way. Some of them might have borne his weight if he were just Donald, but the Master Brah’s

armor added at least a hundred or so pounds, and all that mass turned the branches to toothpicks as he careened through them.

At long last, he found something sturdy enough to stop his descent: the ground. Impact drained his shields further, but they were still more than functional. If only the armor had something to protect him from dizziness, there would have been no evidence of the fall he'd endured. As he slowly pulled himself to his feet and searched the sky, Cyber Geek realized that might have been the point.

The dragon had thrown him into a tree, not just because it meant he wouldn't be able to attack as it flew away, but because the branches would slow him down enough to make sure he wasn't killed in the fall. It was tactically sound and also oddly considerate. Cyber Geek jogged over to the nearest clearing and scanned the stars, searching for a winged white monster flying below them. There was nothing, which said a lot given how far the helmet let him see. Presumably the creature had gone to ground as soon as it was out of sight; that, or it could move a lot faster than it had with him in tow.

Cyber Geek lowered his head and began to search the area. He had a sneaking suspicion that no amount of looking would turn up his quarry, but he still felt compelled to try. Just... not that hard. This wasn't like the monster in the club or the robbers in the office. These villains seemed to be going out of their way not to hurt anyone.

Somehow, hunting one of them just didn't conjure that same fire for justice the other occasions had.

## Chapter 69

Medley was a monster, and not just because he had fur, scales, and a tail. No, he was a monster in the way he attacked: brutal, ruthless efficiency as he struck Hephaestus's suit over and over again with those powerful claws. The damn things were sharp as a chef's prized knife, and all the strength in his inhuman muscles meant he could use them to punch through nearly any material. With one swipe, he'd torn through the shielding on the upper half of her left arm, exposing wires and circuits that were never meant to see the light of day.

On top of his natural advantage, it certainly didn't help that Medley had clearly been in a lot more fights than Hephaestus. She considered herself tough and knew how to hold her own, but he was on a whole other level. Idly, Hephaestus wondered what sort of person he'd been before his transformation. Someone who liked to scrap, that much was obvious. Either that or his power had come with a whole slew of well-honed instincts and reflexes.

When the onslaught first began, Hephaestus was sure the jig was up. He'd carve through her meta-suit like a plasma beam through, well, damn near anything, and she'd be forced to flee in fire-form. While she was mentally prepared for that if it was needed, she considered it a last-ditch effort for a worst case scenario. Aside from all the time and effort she'd poured into her suit, there was also the fact that no one outside the guild currently knew what the real powers of Hephaestus were. The longer she could keep that genie in the bottle, the longer she might be able to hold on to the secret identity of Tori Rivas.

To her surprise, after Medley drew electronic blood in the form of sparks and wires, his attacks softened. Not by a lot, but by enough. Hephaestus was confused until it clicked: Medley didn't know there was a woman composed largely of sentient fire inside the suit. He thought he was fighting a frail, easily killable human inside high-tech armor, and cutting too deep would run the risk of murdering his prey. And that wouldn't be very hero-like, after all.

With no other choice, Hephaestus seized his hesitation, counterattacking for all she was worth, throwing hard punches that she knew would be blocked just to keep him slightly off-balance. To her great surprise, it worked. The more they fought, metal on scales in a rough jumble of limbs, the less coordinated Medley seemed to get. She rolled away from a swipe of his tail, finally putting a little distance between them, and noticed that he seemed to be swaying, ever so gently, on his feet.

“You’re better than I expected.” As Medley talked, the muscles in his thick neck flexed. Hephaestus noticed the twinkling of metal under the parking lot’s giant lights. Of course! The drugs were finally kicking in, and the more he strained, the faster they pumped through his system.

“I work out,” Hephaestus replied in her robotic, disguised voice. Yeah, she really needed to see if Ivan had a book on banter or something.

“Got a name to go with all that metal?” Medley was circling her carefully, waiting for an opportunity to pounce. He also seemed to be getting steadier, which did not bode well for her. Were the drugs only working when he exerted himself?

“Hephaestus will work.” She tried to sound cavalier about it, but the truth was, deep down, she felt a bit of a thrill at telling someone her villain code name for the first time.

Medley blinked in surprise, tilting his feline head slightly to the side. “Isn’t there already a cape with that name?”

“It’s Greek mythology; you can’t own public domain.” That had come out a bit more defensive than she expected, and a long, sharp-toothed smile spread across Medley’s face.

“Well, Hephaestus, my name is Medley. You might not have heard of me yet—I’m new to the Alliance of Heroic Champions—but I’ll give you the basics: I never give up, I never back down, and I never let my prey go once it’s within reach. Now, I’ve been taking it easy on you, despite the fact that you tried to light me up like a sparkler, but that’s about to change. You’re decently strong, which means I can’t capture you by holding so much back. If you’d like to surrender, I’ll happily accept. Otherwise, whatever injuries you get are your own fault.” Medley stopped circling, that

long tail of his extended out behind him. So far, he'd been using it like a bat, smacking her around with it, but they were both keenly aware of the sharp stinger resting at its tip. He wasn't bluffing. Medley was a living weapon, and as it stood, she had no hope of beating him.

If not for a whisper in her communicator, Hephaestus might have given up all hope of keeping her suit and fled. Instead, she grinned beneath the concealment of her black helmet. As quickly and covertly as she could, Hephaestus began redirecting her suit's power, cranking up the temperature as she did to supplement its waning batteries.

"Sorry, Medley, but I'm not really much of a fighter. We just came to relieve the museum of a few of its less-appreciated exhibits, and with that done, I don't see the need to slug it out with you."

Medley flexed his claws and lowered his stance, the fur on his back standing on end. "From where I stand, you don't have a lot of—HEY!"

As Medley spoke, Hephaestus spun on her heel and sprinted off across the parking lot, almost all of the suit's power cranking through her legs, fleeing as fast as her mechanically enhanced feet would carry her. Thanks to the helmet's rear camera, she could see Medley finally snap to what was happening and begin to give chase. Quick as she was, he was faster, and the gap she'd bought with her surprise began to narrow inch by inch. Still, she poured on the effort, running for all she was worth.

"Where do you think you can go?" Medley roared from behind her. "We're in downtown Dash City, and the police are on their way. There's nowhere to... to run."

His words slurred as he veered to the side—only for a split second, but enough to confirm the drugs were pumping again. It would give Hephaestus a very narrow window of opportunity, one she planned to use as quickly as possible. Sooner or later, he'd shake the chemicals completely, and if she was still around when that happened, everything would go right to shit.

Quietly, she whispered a few words into her communicator, and then turned her head a few inches back to yell at Medley. "Well, good thing for me that I'm not planning on running away!"

“You plan to fight me after all?” Medley was steadying himself out; in moments, he’d be gaining ground again.

“Fuck that shit. I just meant why run when you can fly!” Giving her suit’s power one last burst of juice, she sank down on both feet and pushed off, leaping as high into the air as she could possibly manage. It wasn’t that high; she barely cleared five feet off the ground, even with all the power she’d poured into her suit’s muscles. Thankfully, it was just high enough for a pair of white-scaled claws to grab her outstretched arms and carry her up into the sky.

Below, Medley was coming down from his own leap, clearly meant to catch Hephaestus before she could get away. Whether it was the drugs, the gap, or the surprise, he’d come up short, and with every beat of Bahamut’s wings, they were carried farther and farther out of his range.

“I am really, really glad you came back to check on me,” Hephaestus said.

“You read the rules: one of us goes down, we all go down,” Bahamut replied. “Besides, I had a feeling you’d get yourself in too deep.”

“Judgment later, escape now.”

“About that. I’ve got really good hearing like this, and I can make out the sounds of helicopters coming this way.” Bahamut gestured with her head. “Three at least, and gaining on us fast.”

“Cops?”

“Or reporters. Doesn’t matter. Neither will let us out of their sight. And while I’ve got a ward to help conceal me, you don’t,” Bahamut informed her.

“Shitcrap. I don’t suppose you could outrun them?”

“Normally, maybe. But that suit isn’t exactly light. You’re weighing me down a lot, which means they’ll probably be able to catch up.” Bahamut banked hard to the left, giving Hephaestus an unimpeded view of the city below. She could see flashing lights converging on the museum, expecting to find a group of robbers neatly captured. The AHC wasn’t going to like

that any of them escaped, and if they had any shot of catching her and Bahamut, they'd take it.

"I've got an idea," Hephaestus said.

"Is it a good idea?"

"Holy shit, no. But it might work."

Bahamut let out the sort of sigh that said she'd known the answer to her question when it was asked and was just hoping to be proven wrong. "Guess that will have to do."

"Glad to hear you're on board. Lift me up higher so I can get a hold on your stomach. After that, we have to adjust your grip. And for the love of all that's precious in the world, keep your damn tail lifted."

Bahamut complied, pulling Hephaestus up against her scaled stomach, at which point the armored woman began instructing her on exactly where her claws should be. By the time the maneuver was done, they were clinging tightly to each other in an interspecies hug that was uncomfortable but sustainable for both of them.

"Now, when I say three, you hold on to me for all you're worth and keep your wings steady. Aim for somewhere deserted. I'll get us enough of a head start that we can land and call Tunnel Vision before anyone tracks us."

"How the hell will you... wait, are you kidding me?" Bahamut's head peered down at Hephaestus, confirming that yes, dragons can look panicked under the right circumstances.

"One."

"This is not safer than trying to hide from the helicopters!" Bahamut yelled. She jerked her head upward. With what was coming, the last thing she needed was to not see in front of them.

"Never said it was!" Hephaestus agreed. Despite the danger they were still in, she couldn't shake a feeling of excitement as the world rushed along below them and the semi-distant beat of helicopters could be heard on the wind. "Two!"

“I want it on the record that I deeply regret coming back to save you.”

“So noted,” Hephaestus said. “Three!”

With that, she activated her suit’s thrusters, pouring every last ounce of power she had into them. While it wasn’t enough to get her into the air, it could sure as shit add a kick to Bahamut’s flying speed. The ground went from a rush to a blur as the white dragon with a stomach seemingly ablaze raced through the sky.

\* \* \*

“This is why I love rookies! A rocket dragon. A *fucking rocket dragon*! Have we ever had that before?” Xelas looked around the room, waiting to see if anyone could supply an answer to her clearly very important question. Either no one could or they didn’t care; the heavy atmosphere had been lifted right along with Hephaestus as the final two apprentices made their escape.

Arachno Bro and Thuggernaut were both out of their seats celebrating, and even Balaam looked like he’d cracked a half-smile when word came up that Glyph had safely returned with Pest Control. Even the other council members seemed cheery. Not only had the rookies managed to avoid capture, but they’d put on a hell of a show while doing it. Videos from this were definitely going to be edited together for the Christmas party, where it would be all the more entertaining because everyone knew it turned out all right.

Amid the cheer, Ivan made his way around the table to where Doctor Mechaniacal was seated, watching with the others as a dragon with thrusters on its stomach burned through the night sky. Ivan leaned over to make certain his words wouldn’t be overheard. Though they’d been carefully chosen, the context could change if others heard him uttering them.

“Fighting three of the newest capes on their final trial. Seems like a hell of a steep obstacle to climb over.”



“I already know where you’re going with this, and you can save the implications.” Doctor Mechanial turned slightly in his chair so he could whisper back to Ivan. “My original plan was to have Tunnel Vision tell them the shack had been compromised when they tried to use it, forcing them to hunt in unfamiliar territory for a secure location to transport from, test how resourceful they could be when they had to think on the fly. Which, given what we’ve seen tonight, is a question I’d say was thoroughly answered. Believe me, I would never throw more at these apprentices than I thought they could handle.”

“So they just had bad luck?”

“Oh, I wouldn’t go that far,” Doctor Mechanial replied. “For them to have been caught at such an innocuous task, it seems a fair wager that the AHC was waiting for them. If our uneasy peace has begun to wane, then tonight will have much further-reaching implications than just the capes’ awareness of our newest recruits. But that can wait for later.”

Doctor Mechanial stood from his chair, and as he rose, the rest of the room quieted. “My colleagues, Pseudonym has been kind enough to suggest that, given the harrowing nature of tonight’s trials, we move our observation to Sanctum. It would do well for the apprentices to see their mentors waiting for them when the trial is complete. A little solidarity as it were, after a trying evening.”

There were no objections, so the council and two mentors headed down the hallway, screens lighting up along the way so they could continue to monitor Hephaestus and Bahamut’s unorthodox flight.

\* \* \*

“Why didn’t you step in?” Lady Shade stood with Apollo on top of the museum, concealing them both from the roving eyes of reporters and the cameras that were currently surrounding Medley and a still-unconscious Cold Shoulder. Apollo had snuck on to the scene after dropping off the new superheroes, bringing her along to keep them hidden as they watched it all play out. Yet, even as they watched the whole plan fell apart, Apollo hadn’t lifted a muscle, only silently observing while criminal after criminal escaped.

“If I’d jumped in and helped, what would that have accomplished? The new team would think we didn’t trust them enough to let them work without being watched, or worse, they’d get accustomed to having someone nearby to bail them out.” Apollo shook his head. “Yes, I could have handled the whole thing in moments, but they wouldn’t have learned from the experience. And if we want them to get better, then learning, especially through failure, is going to be key.”

“But you could still go run down the dragon,” Lady Shade suggested. “There’s enough media here that you can claim you were called in to clean up after them.”

“Why would I catch the dragon? I want those thieves to get away,” Apollo replied. “If our rookies can’t claim victory, I’d rather they suffer a complete, humiliating defeat. It works much better in the long run.”

“Because it gives them another chance to catch the villains?” Lady Shade asked.

“That, too. But mostly because tonight is going to eat at them: all the ways they failed, all the ways they were embarrassed and beaten. And over time, they’ll grow to hate these four thieves, blame them for it all. So much so that if the day ever comes that the chance for revenge is offered, they won’t think twice before jumping at it.” Apollo smiled as he looked down at Medley, who was doing his best to answer the reporters yet drowning spectacularly in their sea of questions.

“Tonight, they have learned to hate villains.”

\* \* \*

It took half an hour to land, find a secluded park with an unoccupied bridge they could huddle under, and finally push down on their button to go home. Hephaestus was braced for a lot of things as the cement wall rippled and vanished to reveal their way back to the guild. Surely there would be yelling and scolding: not only had they failed to avoid attention, but they had in fact had somehow drawn a group of capes. She took solace in the knowledge that they’d stuck to the code. No matter what else went awry, no matter how many mistakes they made, that much was true, and she wrapped

that truth around her like a suit of armor that *wasn't* dented and beaten half to shit.

What she hadn't been expecting was the wave of sound that slammed into her and Bahamut, now back in human-form, as they stepped into Sanctum. It wasn't screaming or anger; in fact, it was cheering. All of the council was there, along with Tunnel Vision, Glyph, Pest Control, Arachno Bro, and Thuggernaut. Even Ivan, clad in his Pseudonym outfit, stood in the corner applauding. From the center of the crowd stepped Doctor Mechaniacal, covered head to toe in his own distinctive meta-suit.

"We wanted to be here to greet you both," he announced, the cheers subduing but not dying at the sound of his voice, "because never has a group of apprentices faced such a challenge or handled it with such cool heads. You four did a remarkable job, protecting your score, looking out for each other, and making sure that none of your actions did more than embarrass the capes... and perhaps leave one with the scent of charred fur."

Snickers and giggles came from the council. Doctor Mechaniacal continued. "Since Glyph and Pest Control returned first, we took the liberty of evaluating the paintings you brought back. Based on current black market prices, it was determined that your stolen art will net roughly six hundred thousand dollars—after the guild takes its cuts, of course. That means, my impressive apprentices, that you have all passed your final trial, showing that you can handle even the most unexpected of situations while still staying true to the guild's code."

He turned away from them and motioned to Glyph and Pest Control, who hurried over to stand by Hephaestus and Bahamut. Doctor Mechaniacal raised his arms to the four apprentices who stood beside him and turned his helmet slowly to look at everyone else in the room.

"My fellow councilors and guild-mates, the four villains beside me are no longer apprentices. Although we'll need time to prepare the ceremony to induct them properly, with tonight's success it is my pleasure to announce that they are full members in the Guild of Villainous Reformation!"

If the first round of cheers had been deafening, this one nearly knocked Hephaestus from her weary feet. Instead, she grabbed Bahamut's

hand and lifted their arms into the air. It had taken months of effort to finally reach this moment.

She was damn sure going to savor it.

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## Chapter 70

“One of our members was snagged by a flying dragon, one left her protective shell only to be brought down by drugs, and one let his prey escape by not paying enough attention to his surroundings. I won’t lie to you: this was not a good showing, and certainly not up to the caliber I’d expected from all of you.”

Cyber Geek, Medley, and Cold Shoulder all hung their heads as they sat across from Apollo, the older superhero staring at them patiently from his side of the desk. Medley and Cold Shoulder had required a trip to the AHC’s medical team to receive antidotes for the drugs injected into their systems, which meant they’d had plenty of time to stew in their failure before being called in to Apollo’s office. It was going better than they expected in the sense that no one had been kicked out of the AHC or busted back down to training. Then again, the meeting wasn’t over yet.

“With that said, some of these failures are more forgivable than others,” Apollo continued. “Our resident magical metas have confirmed there was heavy use of sorcery during your fight. As near as we can gather, the dragon had some sort of ward on it which made it difficult to notice. Given that none of your powers are magically based, it’s not surprising that you were susceptible to such charms. That makes the kidnapping of Cyber Geek and the escape of... what did you say the metal-suited one called himself again?”

“Hephaestus,” Medley replied, keeping his usual roar of a voice as meek as possible. It wasn’t a name he was going to forget soon, possibly ever.

“Yes. Cyber Geek getting snatched and the escape of Hephaestus are somewhat more forgivable since both involved a dragon enchanted specifically to slip your attention. What is less understandable, however, is one of the AHC’s superheroes leaving the safety of her ice construct to attack a villain who’d already displayed a use of ranged darts, which good sense would tell you were drugged.” Apollo laid his hand on the after-

action report, a summary of all three superheroes' debriefings along with analysis of the footage from what cameras remained. His own observations were absent from the file, as, technically speaking, he hadn't been there.

"With Cyber Geek already gone, if you hadn't allowed yourself to be removed from the fight, Medley might have been able to subdue Hephaestus before the dragon arrived to carry him away." Apollo's eyes were locked on Cold Shoulder, who squirmed uncomfortably in her chair. There was no great defense springing to mind, no quick turn of wit that would exonerate her. Apollo was right. The results spoke for themselves. They'd all made mistakes.

"Respectfully, sir, the blame for that error falls on me." Medley's voice had just a bit more of its usual strength this time. All eyes looked to his stoic, tiger-like face. "I was the one who told Cold Shoulder to come freeze Hephaestus. I was the one who was supposed to have the criminal secured. She trusted me to be able to contain the threat when I implied I would, and I didn't live up to that trust."

"You had no way of knowing that guy was going to light you on fire," Cold Shoulder said, so stunned by Medley's declaration that she momentarily forgot how uncomfortable she was.

"Doesn't matter. When I told you to leave the safety of the construct and freeze Hephaestus, I was assuring you safety. If I hadn't let myself be distracted, I could have dodged the attack, which I should have at least somewhat expected. Overestimating myself and underestimating an opponent are both honest tactical mistakes. Trusting your teammate isn't."

Apollo considered the scene before him carefully, taking a gauge of the room and the emotions within it. After several seconds of hesitation, he allowed a small smile to grace his lips and gave a soft shake of his curly head. "Well, at least that's one test you didn't fail."

"Say what?" Cold Shoulder whipped her head around so quickly that some of her brunette locks smacked Medley in the cheek.

"Failure isn't pretty, but it happens," Apollo explained. "No one expects any superhero to be perfect. We all lose sometimes. What matters most in these situations isn't the loss in itself: it's what you take away from

it. Aside from failing to be on your guard against magic, Medley was the only one who made an actual tactical error. There are little lessons I expect all of you to take away from tonight, but he should have learned a big one. And it seems he did. Even when the opportunity to pass blame arrived, he recognized his failings and owned up to them. That sort of attitude is what will take you all from rookies to legends.”

Cyber Geek and Cold Shoulder nodded while Medley suddenly turned sheepish. It was much easier to be brave in the face of scorn than praise, at least for him, so he looked away until Apollo spoke again.

“Tonight was bad from a crime-stopping front, but good from a training perspective. We can clearly see some holes in your tactics that need patching. Starting tomorrow, you’re all going to start drilling as a team, learning to fight with one another instead of on top of one another. Also, it’s evident that we need to add a fourth to your ensemble. If any of you had possessed magical tolerance, this battle could have gone very differently. I’ll scout the ranks and see who hasn’t been paired up with anyone yet.”

“Yes, sir.” Cyber Geek hesitated, unsure if the question that had popped into his head would be offensive or not. He quickly decided if he was already a little bit in trouble, he may as well take the opportunity to ask. “I was also wondering, why are we being sorted into a team like this? I don’t object; I much prefer having people backing me up. But I sort of got the impression that we had to learn how to function on our own.”

“In emergency situations like the one you and Medley found yourselves in at the club, that’s absolutely true,” Apollo said. “However, for our newer members, it’s AHC policy to have you work in teams for the first year or so. This allows you to get combat experience, grow your powers, and become a generally more effective superhero, all with the benefit of having people to watch your back and cover your weak spots. Eventually, you’ll all be strong enough for solo work, but as tonight demonstrated, that’s still a ways off.”

“That makes sense.” Cyber Geek felt a wave of relief wash over him. After tonight’s loss, he’d started wondering how he would fare when he didn’t have other capes around to help cover him. It was reassuring to

know it was a long while before he'd have to learn the answer to that question.

"All right, you three. It's late and you all need rest," Apollo told them. "Things have calmed down out there, so consider yourselves all off of standby until you get notice otherwise. I expect you to spend the next few days training, especially on teamwork, but none of you are allowed to start for twenty-four hours. You need time to decompress and think about what happened, so nothing more than the gym for a day, understand?"

All three nodded, then rose from their chairs and saw themselves out of the office. Apollo watched them go, pondering what had just happened. He hadn't expected such a display of loyalty from Medley; the man had seemed like he was meant for solo work from day one. The pairing with Cyber Geek had been a temporary one to get them both acclimated to the AHC community. For him to stick up for a brand new teammate didn't fit with what Apollo had expected. It seemed he'd have to reevaluate how to use Medley in the future, though he didn't particularly regard the revelation as a setback.

Loyalty could be a very useful trait, when leveraged properly.

\* \* \*

Despite everything they'd been through the night before, Tori still had to go to work the next morning. She yawned constantly as Ivan drove them through downtown toward the Vendallia offices. With every involuntary expulsion of air, she glared at her mentor, as though he were personally responsible for her grogginess.

"I told you to go to bed early," Ivan said after the fifteenth or so dirty look. "It's not my fault you spent the rest of the night celebrating."

"Of course I was celebrating. I passed my final trial. I'm a full member of the guild. I'm no longer at risk of dying just from not measuring up. If that doesn't warrant a night of partying and a day off work, then I don't know what does."

"Being a full member of the guild means that your secret identity is now more precious than ever," Ivan countered, spinning the wheel to avoid



a car that had just slammed on its brakes. “And you definitely don’t want to be absent the night after a high-profile heist was pulled. Too many coincidences like that and someone smart will start putting things together.”

“So it’s better to show up clearly tired, as if I was out, oh, I don’t know, robbing a museum?” Tori pointed out.

“Ordinarily, no, but seeing as you’ve been pulling all-nighters for the whole week, people are already accustomed to seeing you exhausted. Honestly, at this point, it would raise more eyebrows if you were actually well-rested.” Ivan turned into the Vendallia parking lot and pulled his car into one of the many empty spots. Sometimes Tori suspected Ivan got here so early just for the good parking.

“Although, you know you don’t have to come in if you don’t want to.” Ivan said the words carefully, as though he were afraid they might break something—which was, in fact, exactly the case. “Even if the official ceremony isn’t until Friday, as of now, you’re no longer an apprentice and as such are no longer compelled to follow my orders. You’ll have quite a nest egg once payment from last night’s job arrives, so you won’t need the money. You’re free to do as you please.”

“Well, free as long as I don’t break the code,” Tori said.

“Obviously.”

Tori unbuckled her seatbelt and smoothed the legs of her suit. “I guess that’s all true, but I’ve spent months building this cover identity. And you’ve shown me just how important our covers can be. Maybe I won’t keep it up forever, but I’m also not going to throw it away on a whim just because I’m tired. For now, Tori Rivas, dedicated intern, is going to keep plugging away.”

“I’m glad to hear it.” Ivan freed himself from his own seatbelt and laid his hand on the door handle. “Honestly, finding a new assistant would be a huge inconvenience. In spite of your contrary nature, you’re surprisingly competent.”

“‘Surprisingly competent.’ And the other apprentices all say their mentors gave the best compliments. They got nothing on you, you big

softy,” Tori said.

“Don’t let it go to your head,” Ivan told her. “I did only say competent, and that was as an assistant.”

“Oh yeah, and what about as an apprentice?” Tori asked.

“Trying, tiring, frustrating, time-consuming, draining of both my food and my patience, wearying, worrying, and all-around unpredictable.” Ivan allowed his usual stoic mask to slide out of place just a touch as a wry smirk wormed its way onto his lips. “And impressive beyond all expectations I could have held. The sort of apprentice I’m proud to say I had even the smallest of hands in shaping.”

“That... was unexpectedly sweet.” Tori turned her head, amazed that the early morning allergies she’d apparently just acquired were able to make her eyes water even through closed car doors. “Okay, you had enough of this sentimental stuff? Because too much more and we might have to hug. I might be able to handle being part of a rocket-powered dragon, but even I have limits to my weirdness threshold.”

“Agreed, I think,” Ivan replied. “Let’s get to work.” With that, he opened the door. All mention of the guild fell away. In public, they were nothing more than Ivan Gerhardt and his wayward, but reforming, assistant.

\* \* \*

Balaam sat in his chambers, re-watching the tape of the prior night’s heist for at least the sixth time. The focus of his earlier viewings had been on his own apprentice; however, Glyph’s minimal involvement overall meant there was little feedback to offer. What occupied most of his subsequent viewings were the antics of Hephaestus as she darted about the field of battle, leaving a wake of chaos behind her. He had to hand it to Ivan’s girl: she was more resourceful than Balaam had expected. When she’d shown up to the trial in a meta-suit, he assumed it would have basic functionality, if that. Instead, it had made the difference more than once in helping the apprentices pull off the job and escape safely.

She was more dangerous than anticipated, which meant he had to revise his plans slightly. The suit would grant her some melee capabilities

along with tricks like her dart cannon and thrusters. It added to her power, but didn't significantly increase it. Hephaestus still suffered from the same weakness she'd had before the suit: she lacked an ability to overwhelm any sufficiently durable opponent. Fire was all well and good, but against those strong enough to shrug off its effects, she was essentially helpless. Granted, her pseudo-intangibility did pose an obstacle, although it was nothing a bit of magic or forethought couldn't overcome. Hephaestus was a thorn: annoying but easily plucked, so long as one had the right tools.

Ivan, the man who had been Fornax, was a much more formidable problem; however, Balaam believed he'd hit upon the right method for dealing with the semi-retired villain. It would be difficult but also potentially highly effective. Assuming, of course, that one lacked enough morality to pull it off.

Balaam had made note of how powerful Glyph's spells had been during the outing; his apprentice had managed to slip past the awareness of every cape on scene. Initially, he'd taken the apprentice for political reasons. He needed to be in the thick of wherever things were interesting, and Ivan's adoption of the would-be code-breaker had made being a mentor all the rage again. But as time wore on, he had noticed that Glyph's wards were surprisingly powerful. The young man could grow as versatile as his education allowed. With proper cultivation, he might even make a dependable asset for Balaam's department. Thanks to the trusting relationship they shared as teacher and student, it was possible that Glyph might even come in handy during the coming events, if he had the stomach for it.

As for the rest of the apprentices, they were unremarkable and unlikely to pose any problem. Few would be involved when the plan came to fruition, and any who were could easily be dispatched. Even Hephaestus didn't constitute an actual threat; she was just one more tool to leverage against Ivan... and, if he were being completely honest, a way to add insult to injury. Ivan had clearly taken a shine to his apprentice, though he tried his best to hide it. Crushing her would hurt him, and anything Balaam could do to hurt Ivan was well worth the time and effort.

Once upon a time, Fornax would have been the right-hand man, if not the outright leader of Balaam's plan. Balaam had seen the unstoppable

monster as a child and gazed in wonderment at the sheer destructive potential packed into one man's fists. When he'd become a meta-human himself, a drive to be like Fornax had spurred Balaam to master his craft. He'd quickly grown from a modest spell-slinger to a sorcerer capable of standing toe-to-toe with all but the most powerful of capes. Then one day he'd been invited into the guild and finally gotten the chance to meet the man who'd inspired him, who'd driven him to be the most dangerous villain he could.

And instead of Fornax, there had only been Ivan. Sure, he'd worn the cheap veneer of the Pseudonym name, but even that was half-assed. Gone was the monster who could level entire city blocks, gone was the terror capes raced away from, gone was one of the handful of meta-humans who could fight on par with Lodestar. In its place was the dull, bland, pointless being known as Ivan Gerhardt, a man who had no interest in villainy, who hung to the sidelines as much as possible, and who helmed an entire section of the guild that seemed utterly pointless.

While Balaam still adored Fornax with every fiber of his being, he loathed Ivan for occupying this world in his idol's place. And he would punish him for it. Oh yes, he would punish him. Even with as much as had to be done to make the plan succeed, Balaam had devoted ample time to ensuring that Ivan would suffer. Perhaps even die. Not a literal death—no one was even certain that was possible—but at least a metaphorical one.

And if Ivan Gerhardt died, perhaps the resurrection of Fornax would begin.

## Chapter 71

Despite the fact that there were only a few hours of free time between the end of work Friday and the guild's ceremony, Tori raced into the basement as soon as Ivan pulled into the driveway. While Thursday had demanded she take a much-needed nap, Tori was determined to get her suit repaired as quickly as possible. Now that she'd actually used it, knowing it was broken left her feeling naked. It was a sensation she wanted to dispel as quickly as possible.

Most of the repairs were simple, some only cosmetic. The biggest fixes needed were the giant gash that Medley had taken out of her left arm and the broken focusing lens on her right gauntlet. She'd also gotten several ideas for easily implementable new features, such as some miniature acetylene torches in the tips of her fingers. Medley's dexterity with his claws in their fight had left Tori wanting a pair of her own. Plus, they'd be useful for spot-fixes in the field if she needed repairs before she could make it to her lab.

She was just finishing up with the left arm when a sound echoed through the quiet basement. It caused her to jump and nearly drop the heavy mechanism in her hands. As her heartbeat slowly returned to normal, Tori realized that the sound had been her phone. In her excitement to get to work, she'd forgotten to switch it over to vibrate, an error she would fix immediately.

Digging through her purse, Tori pulled out her mobile, surprised to see a number she was only recently familiar with on its screen. Donald, absent at work for over a week now, had sent her a text. Much as she was itching to get back to her suit, she felt a bit guilty at the thought of ignoring him. The poor guy had been so worried about becoming disconnected from people in his old life. Not to mention she and the other apprentices had delivered what had to be an embarrassing moment to his team only a few nights prior. Even if he didn't know she was responsible, Tori still felt like she owed him a bit of extra courtesy.

She clicked on the speech bubble icon, loading Donald's message.

*Hey Tori, this is Donald. Hope things at the office are going well! I wanted to see if you were up for showing me that coffee shop you always rave about. It would be nice to make sure Chloe is doing okay. Let me know if you're free sometime this weekend.*

In all the haste of being attacked and held hostage, Tori had forgotten that no one had gotten to try the coffee from Ridge City Grinders. It was a shame; she wanted to steer as much business toward them as possible. Plus, if anyone in that office had needed a caffeine boost more than her, it was Donald. That probably wasn't as much the case anymore, now that he'd have exciting late-night fights with criminals to occupy his time, but it would still be nice to catch up.

The weekend would be tough, though. Ivan's kids were coming, so she'd be staying over at the guild. Tori had planned to use the time to figure out her next steps, where she wanted to live, and how she would use her take from their museum heist. Even if she tried to squeeze Donald in, it felt like tempting fate to leave guild headquarters to meet for coffee with a known cape. While the other villains might not say anything, there was always the possibility Donald would put two and two together. Having just gotten one sword of Damocles out from overhead, Tori was in no hurry to procure a new one.

*Weekend is pretty jammed. I have... group stuff. You know. But I'm free every afternoon next week. Want to meet up after work?*

Tori carried the phone over to her work bench and set it down near the hammer she'd been using to pound out her suit's dents. She was barely back to work before a new text made the phone scoot across the metal surface, causing at least as much of a commotion as the ringer had. With a glance at the clock, Tori finally admitted defeat and snapped it up. There was only a half hour until she had to go anyway, and there was still packing to do.

*Afternoons are good for me. Tuesday?*

Heading toward the stairs, Tori typed in a quick response before stuffing the device in her pocket.

*Tuesday sounds fine. See you at 5:15.*

She had to remember to tell Ivan that she would take a cab home that day; he got cranky about unexpected changes to existing plans. Then again, it was possible that she might be driving herself home come Tuesday afternoon. After all, with over a hundred and fifty grand in the bank, she could easily squeeze a new motorcycle into her budget. It would be nice to have her own vehicle again. It would give her a new level of freedom, which she was still adjusting to having regained. Tori needed to make the transition quickly, though. The longer she stayed like this, the easier it was to get comfortable.

It was about time she started thinking about what her world would be like without Ivan watching over her.

\* \* \*

Donald slowly lowered the phone. Ren hovered nearby, waiting impatiently to hear the verdict. “She said yes.”

“All right!” Ren slapped Donald on the back so hard that the red-haired man nearly went tumbling out of his chair. The two of them were seated in one of the small break rooms that dotted the AHC, waiting for Cold Shoulder to arrive so yet another afternoon training session could start. With what little free time they had, Ren had seized the opportunity to continue his week-long quest of cajoling, berating, and encouraging Donald to finally text Tori and invite her to do something. Today, after a week of being worn down, it had finally worked. As a result of his long effort, Ren was more enthusiastic than Donald at being met with success.

“It’s just coffee,” Donald protested, both because he didn’t want to oversell what had occurred and because an enthusiastic Ren was a danger to those without superhuman endurance.

“What’s just coffee?” Irene asked, ambling into the break room. Outside of her Cold Shoulder costume, she seemed smaller, somehow, and far less imposing. Neither Ren nor Donald was silly enough to believe that; after Wednesday’s fight, they were keenly aware that a fierce warrior lurked below her unassuming surface.

“Donald finally worked up the courage to ask out a girl he works with,” Ren explained, the cheer on his face glowing so brightly he could have been mistaken for Apollo.

“I asked her to go get coffee with me and catch up.” Donald put away the phone and took a few steps away from Ren to avoid another back slap. The first one was already starting to bruise. “And I’m not sure I can really say we work together anymore. I have no idea when the next time I’ll get to go to the office will be.”

“Probably not for a while, the way Apollo is training us,” Irene said. She wasn’t far from the mark; since the Wednesday embarrassment, they’d been drilling as a team constantly, with three sessions per day simulating all manner of different combat environments. All of them suspected the only reason they weren’t being trained twenty-four seven was that other AHC members needed to use the facilities as well.

Ren’s enthusiasm finally dimmed a bit and he shook his head. “The supplemental training is optional, you know. We’re all free to skip it if we want.” Apollo had told them all that when he handed them their new schedules. While each believed it was sincerely true, they also didn’t think for a moment that there wouldn’t be consequences to such a decision.

“I wasn’t complaining, just pointing out that Donald has a full plate,” Irene replied. “I’m not sure when he’ll cram in a date, let alone a day job.”

“Tuesday afternoon,” Donald told her. “And it’s just coffee, not a date. But as long as I’m seen in public, I don’t think Apollo will mind me missing a session. He keeps trying to get us to go out more to be seen. Says it helps remind criminals that the AHC is everywhere and makes regular people think of us as just like them.”

“That a fact? Well, if we can’t do team drills, maybe I’ll take the opportunity to have an afternoon on the town as well,” Irene said. “Ren, you want to go check out a local sculpture exhibit with me?”

“I’ll think about it.” Ren didn’t relish the idea of skipping training, but he was on board with Donald actually pursuing someone he liked. For that, he might be able to justify missing one afternoon of work. Though he



wasn't sure he'd be able to tolerate a whole afternoon of art. "We're not outed superheroes, though, so us being in public doesn't generate PR."

"Unless we go in costume," Cold Shoulder countered. "I bet Apollo would love that: two capes out on the town, enriching themselves with culture. That's the sort of thing that gets you in the news *and* the arts section. Double whammy."

It was a shrewd and accurate point. Worse, it was such a good idea that Ren didn't have a defense for it. Rather than admit defeat, he employed a tried and true combat tactic: he stalled for time.

"Something to think about for sure, but for now, we've got training to do," Ren said. "Let's head over to get started."

"I'm not forgetting about this," Irene warned, though she followed as he led them out of the break room. "Either of you gotten news on our fourth yet?"

"I heard Apollo is making the rounds through all the other rookies, searching for one that best fits our existing team dynamic," Donald told her.

"Do either of you have any idea what that actually means?" Irene asked.

"Not a clue," Ren replied, grateful to have the topic off his plans for next Tuesday. "But he got us you, so the man clearly knows what he's doing."

\* \* \*

"No good. We've already got a redhead," Apollo said, tossing the file into the growing stack of rejects. "Cyber Geek might be in combat a lot of the time, but when he's not, that copper-top is still on display."

Jessica protested before her career's sense of self-preservation could intervene. "But sir, her power—"

"Is a secondary, if not tertiary, concern." Apollo glared at Jessica, who meekly went back to work, sorting through the pile of potential magic metas to pair with the current team. "These kids have the potential to be great. They've got that spark that grabs the media's eye and the public's

heart, but only if we package them just right. That means we need to balance the team carefully, which we can't do by doubling up on unique attributes."

"Here's a good possibility," Barney said, handing over a new file.

Apollo skimmed it quickly before throwing it in the reject pile. "Power is good, and she's blonde, which is a nice touch, but she's too plain."

"Last time you wanted plain," Jessica pointed out.

"That was because Medley is so terrifying, we needed someone to soften him up," Apollo replied. "Cold Shoulder was a good fit for that role; she's unimpressive in almost every capacity, so seeing him fighting alongside and protecting her makes him seem endearing. That said, the role is already filled, so let's cover a new base. The team is significantly lacking in sex appeal on either end of the spectrum."

"Cyber Geek is polling well," Barney pointed out.

"He's polling as loveable, like a clumsy guy you want to root for, which is exactly what we hoped for with him," Apollo said. "Now let's add someone the public wants to fuck, not hug. If we can round the team out with eye-candy, they can be used for just about any appearance or story we want to run."

"I might have one," Jessica said, pulling a new file out from near the bottom of her pile. "She wasn't near the top because she wasn't necessarily a perfect fit, but if you're really focusing on aesthetics, I think she might be a good choice."

Apollo accepted the file and looked it over carefully, starting with the picture on the front page. "A little pale, though some go for that. Black hair, too... would have preferred a blonde for this. She's not thick, but she isn't exactly the lean body-type. I mean, those hips alone..." Apollo flipped a few pages to look at her power and let out a low whistle. "Damn; that would be a solid tactical fit, I'll give you that. Okay, sell me on her. Why this one? Power aside, she doesn't exactly tick all the usual boxes."

“But the boxes are changing,” Jessica said. It was the first time in the meeting she’d felt a bit of traction, and she refused to let it slip away. “The classic pin-up beauty is coming back into vogue. Barney can show you the statistics, but it’s a trend we’ve been watching slowly rise over the years. Right now it’s on the precipice of breaking mainstream; we can get out ahead of the curve. With the right costume, hair, and makeup people, that woman could be the face of the new wave of beauty. If we’re quick and smart enough about it, she might even get credited as ushering the new trend in.”

Now that piqued Apollo’s interest. Trendsetting capes were practically worth their weight in pilfered alien technology. Once that label got hung across their shoulders, every fashion choice they made spurred on dozens of imitations, which could be sold by AHC subsidiaries for a sizable profit.

“Get her in for a test photo session and run it through at least three focus groups,” Apollo ordered. “I want the data and pictures in my hands by no later than noon tomorrow. If she works, then we’re done, but if not, I’ll need to have some backup on hand. We have to get the team rounded out as soon as possible; Cyber Geek and Medley have already made their debuts. If we’re not quick, the public will think of them as solo acts and might buck the idea of them being part of a team.”

“We’re on it,” Barney said. He and Jessica rose from their chairs and reached for the remaining files, but Apollo waved them off.

“Leave them. I’m going to dig through and find a backup or two, just in case Jessica’s hunch is wrong.” He noted that Jessica visibly paled by a few shades before she and Barney bolted from the room. In truth, he trusted Jessica’s judgment even more than Barney’s, but she was only at the top of her game when she thought the stakes were high.

Besides, he really did need to find a spare fourth, just in case. That group had to be ready. If everything went to plan, then next week was going to provide them an opportunity to make a name for themselves unlike almost anything that had ever come before. If they were prepared, that team of rookies could be household names by the time the next weekend rolled

around. Personally, Apollo was rooting for them, partly because he liked them, at least Medley and Cyber Geek.

But mostly because when the dust of what was coming finally settled, he was going to need every PR tool at his disposal.

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## Chapter 72

Tori wasn't exactly sure what she'd been expecting as she and Ivan stepped into the guild. She knew enough of the more frequent attendees to know that none of them seemed particularly big on ceremony. Things appeared to be business as usual otherwise: Ivan was dressed in his dark, nondescript Pseudonym outfit once more and she was clad in her apprentice costume. Nevertheless, she felt unsettled. Her bag had been left in the car with assurances that it would find its way to her room, so there was nothing in her hands as Ivan walked her down a deserted hallway and into a small elevator.

"This isn't some final test, is it?" Tori blurted out just as the doors closed. "Like, you all say I've passed but then make me and the other three fight to the death to see who really gets into the guild?"

Ivan didn't respond immediately, which set Tori's teeth on edge. She began working through how in the hell she'd take down the others without so much as a shoulder plate from her meta-suit. Finally, Ivan answered, and when he did, she could swear there were the barest hints of amusement in his voice.

"If that were the case, I'd have almost certainly let you bring along some of your weaponry. It wouldn't look very good on me if my apprentice were killed off quickly, after all."

"Oh, come on. We both know I might go down, but I sure as shit wouldn't be the first one out." Though her words were rough, her nerves were settling. Ivan wasn't the sort to joke often; if he felt up to quipping then things must be on the up and up. Or he really wanted to see her die, which seemed unlikely. Ivan was the sort that, if he wanted someone dead, he'd do it by his own hand.

At last, the elevator doors opened to a room Tori had never seen before, which wasn't surprising given how little of the guild's building she'd been exposed to. It was a vast space, bigger than the gym in her old high school from another life. In the center was a hardwood floor—no

doubt for dancing—surrounded by a moat of flat red carpet. Buffet stations and bars were stationed in all of the room’s corners, each manned by robots a lot less sophisticated than Xelas. Across from the entrance was a large stage currently occupied by seven other bodies: her fellow apprentices, their mentors, and Doctor Mechaniacal in full meta-suit.

To Tori’s enormous shock, between her and that stage was a veritable sea of bodies. She’d never seen this many people in the guild at all, let alone all at once. Some people were in colorful costumes that smacked the outskirts of her brain with familiarity, while others wore suits or tuxedos. Most were humanoid, but an occasional face full of tentacles or eight-foot tall green ogre peered back at her through the more mundane stares. It was one of the most surreal scenes she could recall, made all the more strange by the fact that they were all looking right at her. If not for the gentle pressure of Ivan’s hand on her shoulder, she might have stood there, dumbfounded, staring back at them.

At his touch, her brain finally clicked back into gear. She walked toward the stage with as much composure as she could muster. For the first time, she was glad her apprentice costume came with a mask, as it covered the blush that was trying to rapidly creep across her face.

“You could have warned me about this,” Tori whispered darkly under her breath.

“And miss the opportunity to see my composed apprentice so taken by surprise? All the money in the guild’s coffers couldn’t have convinced me to give up a chance like that,” Ivan replied.

Tori might have said more if she weren’t trying to swim through a sea of stares on her trek to the stage. Had the others been subjected to this? Only if their mentors got as much of a kick from screwing with them as Ivan did, she supposed, so it seemed likely. As she walked, Tori nodded her head at the few guild members in the audience she recognized. All three of the Bytes were there, with one of them, Gig, already so drunk she was leaning on Kilo’s shoulder for support. Kristoph was in the crowd; even amid so many other villains, he’d been given a wide berth. Still, he smiled and waved at her, and Tori gave a small wave back. Johnny Three Dicks was hanging out next to Xelas and Morgana, all of whom grinned as they

saw her pass. Even Stasis offered up a small nod of greeting. Gork made a weird motion with her giant hands that Tori chose to assume was friendly but didn't bother attempting to mirror.

Then it was over. They climbed a set of wooden stairs to approach the stage. Ivan guided her to a stop at the end of the row, where they flanked Beverly and Thuggernaut. Tori and her fellow apprentice exchanged a single nervous glance before Doctor Mechanial's voice filled the giant room, instantly snaring the attention of every criminal, ruffian, and crook assembled before him.

"It is not often that we have the chance to welcome new members into this guild. Too many who share our passion for freedom, for life outside the rigid confines of laws designed for humans, are unwilling or unable to curb their baser instincts enough to live within the shelter and rule of our organization. We are a rare breed, each and every one of us. Powerful enough to survive the capes, but wise enough to know there is value in avoiding conflict. Each time we take in refugees, be they from a confluence or an invocation of the Orion Protocol, it is with the sincere hope that they will one day stand on this stage. Sadly, too few ever make it so far. This is what makes today so special. I cannot recall the last time an entire group of recruits all showed the level of intelligence, judgment, and skill required to satisfy our entrance criteria. Yet here behind me stands just such a group."

Doctor Mechanial swept his hand back to gesture to the apprentices. As his fingers were directed at her, Tori felt a rush of accomplishment she hadn't been expecting. Among the crowd, several eyes grew misty, though whether it was from joy at the new members or simple nostalgia over when they had stood on the same stage varied from villain to villain.

"I know none of us are the type to revel in ceremony and speeches," Doctor Mechanial continued. "Yet so many of you came today because you know that, for us, this is no mere empty ceremony. All of us, together, are the unlovable, the un-reformable. We are the people who were deemed incapable of existing alongside society. But we did just that in the forming of this guild. We have done more than simply build a place to sleep and eat and plan elaborate heists. We have found a place where we, at long last, belong. All of you remember how important that feeling was the first time

you truly experienced it here, and I know that's why you've come out to support the welcoming of our newest members. Because this guild is more than just an organization and a council and various members. To me, from the beginning, this guild has been a family. It is a place for people like us, the ones who had no place of their own. We made it ourselves, carved out a space in the world that we could call home. And today it is my great honor to welcome four new members into that home, to be a part of that family."

Thuggernaut was crying freely behind Beverly, whose eyes seemed to be misting up a bit as well. Even Tori felt her throat get tight. As much respect as she'd always had for Doctor Mechaniacal's brain and inventions, she'd never realized just what a gifted orator he was. The man could *speak*. In the sea of faces before her, Tori could see features that had been plastered all over the evening news and wanted posters crying freely. He'd hit them right in the sore spot, touched on the true heart of what made this guild possible. It wasn't the code—that was just the framework so people knew what to do. No, for the first time since she'd arrived, Tori could finally see what had been in front of her all along: the guild gave everyone who could accept it a place to belong.

Her first tear fell before Tori fully realized the implications of her revelation. It gave every one of its members a home. A family. And now, that included her. For the first time since she'd sat in a hospital room, watching the life of her parents slip away one tooth-grinding beep at a time, the weight of Tori's self-imposed loneliness grew just the slightest touch lighter.

"As you can all see, our new members still wear the garb of apprentices and are followed by their teachers," Doctor Mechaniacal told them. "If you will please be patient and help yourself to the refreshments, we will retire to a private area where they can be presented with their first official guild costumes. When I return, it will no longer be with guided apprentices but with full members of our guild."

"Wait," Tori whispered, pragmatism quickly overtaking the swell of emotion. "You all got to design our costumes?"

"Well, it's not a surprise if we have you do it," Ivan quietly replied back. "You can change them as you see fit now that you're members. This



is just for you to wear tonight as you meet the rest of the guild.”

“Still wish I’d had a little input on whatever I’m about to put on,” Tori replied.

Ivan chuckled quietly, a little more humor in his laugh than Tori was entirely comfortable with. “Come on. After all this time, don’t you trust me?”

\* \* \*

Truth be told, it wasn’t all that bad. Lots of black and red, not that far off from the Pseudonym color palette, actually, with a bit of a flame motif around the trim. It was sleek and contoured to her body well, giving enough padding to preserve modesty but otherwise minimizing the amount of fabric she’d have between herself and the meta-suit.

Tori turned around in the dressing room, one of four that had been set up in the small room behind the stage, checking the outfit from all angles. It didn’t give her the same feeling of transformation as getting into her meta-suit had, but she certainly wasn’t recognizable as Tori Rivas in it, and she clearly was no longer an apprentice either.

“You had help with this, didn’t you?” Tori called. Ivan was waiting outside along with all the other mentors and Doctor Mechaniacal, the established guild members talking amongst themselves. Even Balaam was being good, though that mostly consisted of just not talking to Ivan.

“We all had the option to consult with Silk Spitter,” Arachno Bro answered. “He’s the best costume design expert in the guild’s history.”

“But we also came up with our own designs and ideas,” Thuggernaut added. “We all tried to create an outfit that would fit your new personas, though if we missed the mark, we won’t take offense if you change things. These are ultimately a best guess.”

“I can’t speak for the others, but you hit mine right on the head.” Tori could hear Beverly throw back her own curtain and emerge, followed by the sound of light clapping and appropriate compliments. Curiosity got the better of her, and without thinking, Tori emerged as well.

Unlike Tori's outfit, Beverly's had been built for more than to be stuffed into a meta-suit. The emerald green armor perfectly matched her eyes, the trunk section covering her chest like something out of a gladiator film. More armor covered the leather skirt that flared wide and stopped just above her knees. The matching boots ran halfway up her long shins and on her forearms were a set of studded bracers. Most eye-catching of all was the mask, which almost looked reptilian unless one had seen Beverly shift, in which case they instantly recognized the dragon that had inspired it. Aside from the green coloring, it was actually quite similar to Thuggernaut's costume, a touch that was clearly not lost on Beverly as she stared down at her new armor.

"You look badass," Tori said. She did too; Beverly looked like she was ready to step into a battle, not go mingle with other villains.

"And it's all enchanted to shift with you," Thuggernaut told her. "Changes color too, so it will always match your scales."

"I love it," Beverly said, and a moment later she was hugging the oversized brute, who did his best to return the affection without injuring her.

"Gotta say, my main man Arachno Bro knocked this one out of the park." Lance emerged from behind his curtain in a suit that looked as though it were made entirely of rings and pockets. It ran the entire length of his body, seemingly unbroken; though when he moved Tori could make out a few seams where pieces might come off as well as chunks of armor concealed under its bulk. The color was off-white like an old eggshell, and the matching mask covered his entire head, rendering him seemingly featureless. Not even his eyes could be made out, though they still functioned, as evidenced by the effortless way he reached up and met the strange hand of his mentor in a high-five that echoed off the walls.

"Figured you should look the part," Arachno Bro replied, though no one else seemed to have any idea what they were talking about.

"Mine's a good fit," Tori said, turning to Ivan. He stared at her carefully, as though he weren't entirely sure that it was truly his apprentice under the new threads. Which, in a way, it wasn't.

“I’ve been assured the fabric is as durable as we can engineer,” Ivan told her. “And it goes without saying that they’ve been designed to shift with your form. Also... you look quite lovely. I mean, intimidating. Like a real villain.” Ivan gave up trying to clarify and instead coughed into his hand, an action that drew chuckles from Thuggernaut, Arachno Bro, and even Doctor Mechaniacal.

“I think what Pseudonym is trying to say is that you truly look the part of a grown, powerful villain,” Doctor Mechaniacal said, stepping in after the laughter died down. “He’s bad with words, but if you search carefully, the sentiment shines through.”

Tori bobbed her head in agreement but didn’t bother replying. She already knew what Doctor Mechaniacal was telling her, as well as what Ivan had been trying to say. The gruff old villain always seemed stymied when things took a turn for the overly-emotional or sincere; a trait she’d actually grown to find endearing. Beverly and Thuggernaut could have their hugs; sending Ivan into awkward silence told her all she needed to know about how important this moment was.

“Sorry, everybody, mine took a few minutes to figure out,” Warren called before pushing the curtain aside. Like Tori, his costume featured black heavily, though that was just about the only similarity they had in common. While she’d been given red as an accent color, his outfit sported purple, not unlike the color his fingers would glow when etching a rune. Along with a mask, pants, long-sleeved shirt, boots, and gloves, his outfit also came with a billowing cloak that hung from his shoulders, almost like a cape if the cut had been slightly different. Instead of making him look like a superhero, however, the addition caused him to resemble a sorcerer, calling on the classic look of a robe without actually using one.

“As I’m sure you can tell, there are heavy enchantments woven throughout that garb,” Balaam told him. “Protective and concealing magic, of course, but also many an augmentation charm channeled into the gloves to increase the potency of your wards.”

“Thank you very much, sir. I will strive to make you proud every time I wear it.” Warren bowed to his teacher, who waited several seconds and then returned the gesture.

“And with that, it’s almost time to send you back out on stage,” Doctor Mechanial told them. “But we should probably wait for at least a few more minutes; if I don’t break up these ceremonies into small chunks, people get antsy. And antsy villains, even if they don’t mean harm, can be more trouble than they’re worth. So, while we wait for the last of the group to finish raiding the refreshment tables, why don’t we go ahead and do presents?”

“Shit,” Lance said, glancing at Arachno Bro. “Were we supposed to get you all thank-you gifts? I’m so sorry, man, no one told me, but I definitely would have if I knew—”

“Chill,” Arachno Bro said, putting a clawed hand on Lance’s shoulder. “We’re the ones who give the gifts. Costumes are covered by the guild, but these come from us. Something to help each of you on whatever path you choose from here.”

With that, the four mentors lined up directly across from their apprentices. Silence overtook the room.

## Chapter 73

A solemn air swept over them, the cheer fading into the background as Doctor Mechanical wheeled out a small table with four boxes lined up on top. He took it to the mentor nearest to him, which happened to be Arachno Bro. The spider-like man gave a nod of thanks to the guild's leader, then carefully took one of the boxes and walked it over to Lance. With a steady hand, he held it out to the apprentice he'd trained, who accepted and opened it uncertainly.

"It's a book," Arachno Bro explained as Lance pulled a hefty tome out from the depths of the box. "I mean, you can see that. But it's a book cataloguing as many meta-insects and their native habitats as I could find. Once you learn how to summon more of those, you're going to be a real menace, and this should serve as a good map for that journey."

"That is awesome." Lance's voice was hushed with awe as he flipped through the pages, taking note of the carefully-gathered information crammed on every available surface. Even at a glance, he could recognize the unique penmanship of his mentor and knew that Arachno Bro had personally compiled all this information just for him. "Thank you so much. Not just for the book. For everything."

"Thank you, as well," Arachno Bro replied. "I'd forgotten what joy could be found in teaching and molding young minds. It's a pastime I've been unable to indulge in since my accident, yet you gave it back to me. I will always look back fondly on my time as your mentor."

While they spoke, Doctor Mechanical moved down the line, arriving at Balaam. The sorcerer plucked a long box from the top of the table and walked it over to Warren. Visibly nervous, Warren accepted the gift, carefully opening it to reveal a slender rod covered in runes. At his touch, it sparked and began to glow with the same purple energy that surrounded Warren's fingers when his magic was in use.

"Every good caster needs a wand or a staff," Balaam said, holding out his hand to manifest his own staff, which stood a few feet taller than

him and housed a pulsing red jewel at its crown. “I concluded that the wand would be easier to write with. It can channel your energies and augment them, adding on to the power woven through your costume. More importantly, it also has the capacity to store a single rune at a time, allowing you to cast in a hurry with nothing more than the flick of a wrist.”

“I... Thank you so much, sir. Such power is more than I deserve.” Warren lowered his head, even as he kept his eyes trained on the glowing wand.

“Nonsense. Even if you are now a full guild member, you will always have been my apprentice. I can’t very well have a student I trained getting caught or killed as soon as they leave my tutelage. Use the tools you’ve been given and have a long, successful career as a villain,” Balaam instructed him.

The table and Doctor Mechanical kept rolling to Thuggernaut, who’d inserted himself between Ivan and Balaam, likely to ensure the evening stayed peaceful. The giant man reached down and plucked the smallest box from the table. He held it out to Beverly, who broke the seal with the nail of her thumb and pulled out a small golden ring with a curiously-designed rune etched into its center.

“Blending in is hard for us big folks,” Thuggernaut told her, watching as she slipped the ring on to her right hand. “But you’ve got the option of slipping away into obscurity, thanks to your transformations. Seeing as you’ve got all the fighting power a meta could need, I decided that your gift should be something to make getting in and out of dangerous situations a little easier. Press the rune in the center.”

Beverly dutifully obliged, angling the ring on her fourth finger down so she could press the rune with her thumb. Just like that, she was gone, as the gasp from Tori and Warren both attested to.

“What?” Beverly said, her voice seeming to manifest from nothing.

“You just disappeared, that’s what,” Tori snapped. Moments later, Beverly reappeared, thumb no longer in contact with the rune on the ring. She looked at Thuggernaut for explanation, which he cheerfully provided.

“As long as you wear the ring and touch the rune, you’ll be invisible. While it recharges naturally, it doesn’t have a lot of juice. You shouldn’t count on it for more than a minute per day. Just long enough to slip out of view and become a dragon, or vice versa.”

“Wow, that *is* functional,” Beverly said, gazing at her ring with new appreciation. “I love it. Thank you, Thuggernaut!”

As they hugged, Doctor Mechanical continued his trek to the sole remaining mentor. Ivan plucked the final box from the table and handed it nonchalantly to Tori. It wasn’t as big as Lance or Warren’s boxes, but it certainly was larger than Beverly’s. Tori had no clue what could be inside. She pulled the packaging open to reveal a small orb suspended between a pair of metal rings.

“What is... oh, no way.” While the strange device seemed alien at first, the longer Tori gazed at it, the faster her mind worked, recalling half-scribbled diagrams in highly theoretical research notes she’d glimpsed throughout her studies. Carefully, as though the orb were made of a soap bubble that would pop on contact, she lifted it up, unsurprised to find that it moved as if it had no mass at all.

“Ivan, this is a miniature gravitational anomaly generator.” Tori’s eyes were so large they threatened to stretch outside the confines of her new mask. “These don’t even technically exist.”

“You’d be surprised what can be purchased when one has guild connections,” Ivan said. Of course, everyone in the room knew he’d just bought it from Doctor Mechanical, but keeping up a certain amount of vague mysteriousness was important for villains, even amongst each other. “Besides, after Wednesday’s debacle, I thought you could use a little more mobility.”

“Hey, so, um, you got to hear the explanation of what all our stuff does,” Beverly pointed out. “Anyone want to tell us what the deal with the weird orb is?”

“It can generate a field of reduced weight, even complete weightlessness,” Tori babbled excitedly. “It will *tremendously* scale back the amount of thrust I’ll need for my initial momentum and...” She trailed

off as the eyes looking at her began to glaze over. Perhaps this was not the time to try and educate everyone on theoretical gravitational anomaly devices, so she decided to cut to the chase. “When properly equipped, it will let my suit fly.”

“Sweet,” Beverly said.

“Badass,” Lance echoed.

“And with that, the giving of gifts has concluded,” Doctor Mechanical announced. “Your mentors will hold on to the less portable items you’ve received for convenience. You should all wait here and listen closely. I shall introduce you one at a time to the guild. When your name is called, you are to walk on stage and join me. These are the final moments where the vestiges of apprenticeship will cling to you, so if you have anything to say to your mentors, feel free to do so.”

The room immediately began to split off as Doctor Mechanical exited the room. They could hear his unmistakable voice crackling over the speakers as he called the rest of the guild back to order. Amid the not-quite-whispered conversations, Tori looked at Ivan, still tucked under his idiotic Pseudonym mask.

“Feels a little odd to think about having a heart-to-heart. I mean, I’m going to see you on Sunday night. Not much to say now that couldn’t be said then.”

“Technically quite correct,” Ivan agreed.

“Except that, I should say that I really like my orb. It’s an amazing gift, one that means the world to me.” Tori looked down at the weightless device, noting that she could see a distorted reflection of herself in its depths. The masked woman staring back at her bore almost no resemblance to the thief who’d stupidly busted into a vault owned by a guild of villains. She was so much stronger now and knew a tremendous amount more about how to survive. She also knew that none of it would have been possible if the man in front of her hadn’t agreed to take an apprentice.

“Also... thanks for saving my life,” Tori said. “I know we didn’t exactly want to be paired up, but you had a choice, and you chose to save



me. To teach me. To give me the best chance of surviving in this world. I'll always be thankful for that."

Ivan took a step toward her and rested his hand on top of her head, mussing her hair where it emerged from under her mask. "I owe you a debt of thanks, too. Teaching you has reminded me why this guild was founded, why it matters. We are more than the guard dogs who keep the more disruptive metas at bay. We give guidance and direction to those who would hear it. We are a refuge for those who are lost. Amid all the dirtier matters we deal with, I'd managed to forget that. Thank you, Tori, for reminding me why I helped create this guild in the first place."

"Does that mean I can expect to see Pseudonym out and about, tearing up the streets?" Tori asked.

"I highly doubt it," Ivan replied. "But one never knows what the future holds in store. Oh, before I forget, there is one more thing I wanted to tell you: wear your work clothes when you come home on Sunday. I have one more gift, though far less substantial or useful than the orb."

"That's all the info I get?" Tori asked.

"Surprises aren't much fun if you know what they entail," Ivan told her.

Overhead, Doctor Mechaniacal's voice reached a crescendo, and he loudly called for Bahamut to come out and join him. Beverly gave Thuggernaut one last glance, and then hurried out of the room. No sooner had she vanished than a wave of applause crashed through the speakers as the guild welcomed its newest member.

"He does these alphabetically," Ivan whispered. His words came only a few seconds before Doctor Mechaniacal called for Glyph, who took a deep breath and tried to walk with as much confidence as he could muster. This time, the applause sent butterflies through Tori's stomach, as she realized there were only seconds until he called—

"Hephaestus!"

The woman who had stared down a team of capes on her first official guild outing felt her courage tremble for a sliver of a second, then

she mustered up her gumption and strode toward the door. Stepping out onto the stage, Tori faltered momentarily as the lights blinded her. Blinking away the spots in her eyes, she continued forward to stand next to Glyph as the sea of villains, so many of them unfamiliar, clapped and cheered. Tori could make out the electronic whistling of Xelas and a lot of hooting that seemed to be coming from Johnny.

“Pest Control!” Doctor Mechanical bellowed, and seconds later Lance arrived, taking the empty spot next to her. He was washed in cheering as well, until Doctor Mechanical held up his armored hand and the room went silent.

“With their names chosen, their trials overcome, and their apprentice costumes shed, these four have now officially completed all requirements to join our ranks. Please, guild-mates, welcome our newest official members!”

If the cheering at their names had been enthusiastic, this seemed downright overpowering. What made it all the more entrancing was that they weren’t cheering because Doctor Mechanical told them too; the joy in their claps and screams was far too sincere. They were genuinely happy to see four new members pass the bar of entrance and become one of them. Their guild, their family, had grown a little bit bigger today, and that was all the reason they needed to be overjoyed.

It was over, Tori realized. She, Beverly, Lance, and Warren, they were all free, and no matter what paths they might choose to go down from here, they all had a home.

\* \* \*

Nexus walked down the charred, smoldering streets, stepping over a couple of corpses that had melted in place. Above him, the sky was dark as a broken world tried in vain to repair itself. Amid the black clouds, red streaks of lightning crackled, threatening those who dwelled below with more torment. Well, if there had been anyone living below, anyway. This was the site where it had all begun, and as such, Nexus was the only creature who drew breath among the shattered streets.

It had been a fine bit of entertainment, one of the best dimensions he’d watched so far. The cleanup was never as interesting anyway, so he

was glad most of the ones capable of doing it were dead. Perhaps this dimension would take new, interesting turns that he'd yet to witness. It wasn't likely, though. While every dimension in the multiverse was unique, some had more pronounced differences than others. Here, the alterations were minimal, and that was reflected in how the event had played out.

Even now, half a country away from where they were desperately hunting down the monster who'd unleashed living hell upon the world, Nexus knew how things were unspooling. By sundown they would catch up to their quarry, Lodestar leading the pack. The woman would be half-insane by this point, so lost in grief that she could scarcely function through the blind, drowning anger. Nexus would be there for the next battle, the one that cracked the earth and ushered in decades of despair; however, until then, he was content to simply stroll through the aftermath. One had to get a good appreciation for all that went into a show. The buildup and the fallout were almost as important as the spectacles themselves.

Still, this was merely a placeholder, something to fritter away the time while he waited for the next main event to begin. This dimension was like so many others—no unique people who might sway or shift the tide of battle, no factors that made things deliciously unpredictable. It was like watching a rerun of the same show he'd seen a hundred times. No matter how much he might enjoy it, it lacked the thrill of the unknown.

It was better than nothing, though. And anyway, by his observation, it would be a few days at most until the dimension with Quorum hit this junction. All the pieces were in play and moving into position; once the first move was made, chaos would be on its heels, and Nexus would be waiting to take in the show.

Until then, he'd keep busy by taking in the usual sights. And it was always fun to watch that final battle, anyway. No matter how many times he saw it, there was just something special about that fight. The brutality, the emotion, the regret, the pain... so rarely in life did fate force an encounter on par with the one that would happen at sunset. While Nexus couldn't wait to see how the other dimension fared, this would do for now.

He truly never tired of watching Lodestar kill Fornax, after all.

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## Chapter 74

Tori didn't wake up in her guild quarters until halfway through Saturday, the night of celebration and mingling with her other guild-mates having taken a heavy toll. After a late breakfast, long shower, and a few minutes spent in fire-form to shake off the remnants of a hangover, she got down to business.

Logging in to her bank account, Tori found that she had indeed been credited her share from the museum heist, minus about twenty grand. Interestingly, a memo in the deposit line showed the money coming from Vendallia Industries as a bonus with the notation of "Lab expenses deducted." Doctor Mechanical had warned her that the tech she'd used to build her suit would eventually have to be paid for, so the deduction made sense. Either way, a hundred and thirty grand could still buy her all the components she needed to fully refine her suit.

Before that, however, there were pragmatic issues to deal with. Closing the tab with her banking information, Tori began to hunt through local apartment listings. Hephaestus might be able to bunk at the guild, but Tori Rivas was going to need a place to stay if she wanted to keep selling her cover. Besides, much as she liked the guild, having somewhere to call her own seemed prudent. Though, as she skimmed through the pricey listings, it became evident that she couldn't afford any of the really good spots on her own. Well, she could if she used her thief money, but the whole point of an apartment in the real world was that it needed to be a place Tori the administrative assistant could afford. Hephaestus, however, would need a lot of space, plus security, since she wouldn't have Ivan's basement to use as a lab anymore. Those requirements weren't satisfied by the salary she pulled down at Vendallia.

How the hell did normal people find decent places to live? Well, the obvious answer was that most people weren't concealing the fact that they were meta-humans aligned with a secret organization of supervillains. That opened up options like roommates, who would split the rent and lower costs.

Tori tapped absentmindedly on the side of her computer, a new idea flitting through her head. Shutting the machine off, she threw on a slightly less decrepit t-shirt and a pair of jeans in place of her sweats and left her room. Three doors over, she knocked firmly until the door opened to reveal an awake, albeit not quite alert, Beverly.

“Do you ever sleep?” Beverly asked, pulling open her door the rest of the way.

“It’s past noon, get over it,” Tori said. She sauntered in, shut the door behind her, and whipped around to face her tired friend, too excited to bother with subtlety. “Where do you live?”

“For the love of... are you trying to get metaphysical before I’ve even had a bowl of cereal?” Beverly walked over to her cupboard. She yanked out a small pack of sugar-frosted non-nutrition, tossed its contents in a bowl, grabbed a milk jug from her mini-fridge, and filled the bowl nearly to the brim.

“No, I meant literally,” Tori explained. “When you’re not here, where do you live?”

“I did live with my family,” Beverly replied. “Though I don’t think that’s going to fly anymore. We’re mending bridges, but once a family member turns into a monster and nearly tramples half the people in the house, they’re not exactly welcome to come strolling back through the front door.”

“That wasn’t your fault,” Tori said. “You’d literally just been turned. No one has good control at that point.”

“Which is why I’m forgiven,” Beverly told her. “All the same, I scared the living hell out of them. Even if we both know I’ve got a better handle on this now, they might have a hard time believing me. To them, this is all impossible to understand, you know? Besides, I’d been thinking of moving out at the end of the year anyway. Getting dragon powers is as good a reason to take that plunge as any.”

“I’m sorry you can’t go home, but on a selfish level, I’m sort of not. See, I had an idea. What if you and I—” Tori spread her arms to draw out

the moment, then clapped her hands together and finished the proposal “— become roommates! We can split the rent, help each other with cover identities, and since we’re both guild members, we don’t have to hide our extracurricular activities.”

“Mmm.” It was hard to tell whether Beverly’s reaction a result of the idea or her breakfast; either way, she munched through a few more spoonfuls without saying anything. “Don’t take this the wrong way,” she began, “but aren’t you the sort that needs a lot of space? I may not know a lot about tech stuff, but I saw you work when we were in the desert. You spread out *everywhere*. I like you, I do; I just don’t know that I want to live with someone who dominates the living room so they can build mechanical dolphins with grappling hooks for noses.”

“Not really what I do, but also not the worst idea for aquatic warfare,” Tori said, making a mental note for future projects. “Anyway, we’d have to get a space for me to use as a lab, but I promise not to let it spill into communal areas. This place is supposed to be a cover for us anyway, remember? Tori the office-worker can’t very well have advanced machinery littering the house.”

“I guess that’s true,” Beverly agreed. She tilted back her bowl and shoveled down the rest of her breakfast, slurping her milk as she went. “Okay, I’ll take a look with you and see if there’s anything that fits what we’d need. Did you check and see if the guild has special deals or places set aside for us to rent? Maybe with a hidden lab already built in?”

“I... no, it never occurred to me. Do you think the guild really would have stuff like that?” Tori asked.

“Given everything I’ve seen, nothing would surprise me,” Beverly replied. After a moment’s consideration, she added, “Okay, that’s probably not true in the slightest, but I wouldn’t be shocked if they had some sort of real estate connection. How about you find out if that’s a thing while I take a shower?”

“Sounds good.” Tori headed for the door but stopped just before her hand landed on the knob. “An actual shower, right? Not slipping back into bed as soon as I leave the room?”

There was a very notable delay before Beverly let out a long sigh of defeat. “Fine, just the shower. I’ll be ready in twenty minutes.”

“I’ll be back in twenty-one,” Tori said, and just like that, she was out the door.

\* \* \*

“And lastly, I’d like to bring up our defense system,” Apollo said. His pen ran to the last item on the bulleted list, copies of which were supposedly in front of every other member of the Champions’ Congress. Quorum, at least, could be seen following along, but with the remote terminals Lodestar and Professor Quantum were using, it was impossible to tell. Though the detached, bored tone in Professor Quantum’s voice did give Apollo an indication of his distraction.

“The system was just upgraded last year,” Professor Quantum said. No doubt if challenged he could probably have given the exact date and time of said upgrade, along with all the steps he’d taken to complete the task. Even at half-attention, he presented more brainpower than some state populations combined.

“Yes, it was,” Apollo agreed. “However, there hasn’t been a full-scale test of the lockdown protocol in over five years. According to the AHC’s protocol we’re supposed to do them annually.”

“Those things are... sort of a pain,” Lodestar admitted, the symbol flickering at her brief pause. “No matter how many times we tell people we’re doing a drill, they always panic when the AHC is suddenly covered by a giant glowing energy-dome, to say nothing of all the guns and defenses that pop out. Everyone assumes Ridge City’s greatest heroes are under attack, and we have to spend the next few days sweeping up all the chaos that ensues.”

“A pain or not, you three saw the importance in making sure our people had a safe place to recover and shelter when the need arose,” Apollo pointed out. “As it stands now, we’re way out of compliance. If you’d like to amend the protocol, then by all means, let’s put a motion on the floor. Otherwise, I can have a drill ready to proceed on Tuesday.”



“So soon?” Quorum said. “Those take a while to coordinate with all the emergency response agencies.”

“I wouldn’t have brought it up if I hadn’t already laid the groundwork,” Apollo assured him. “I can task our newest members with canvassing the area and ensuring the people know it’s a drill. That will get them some face time with the public as well as keep things under control. All the necessary agencies have been contacted and are waiting for final confirmation of our plans. We can knock it out in a couple of hours and be good for another year. Or we can change the protocol, if anyone wants to \_\_\_”

“Just run the damn thing,” Professor Quantum said. “If it gets choppy, all the better to train the rookies. Though, it’s a waste of time; my designs and technology are both flawless.”

“Says the guy who blew the city’s power grid the first time we tried to turn the system on,” Lodestar reminded him. “Apollo is right. Five years of tinkering needs to be tested before we depend on it. Use the full lockdown-mode and make sure everything is running well. And try to keep the peace, please.”

“Rest assured, everyone will be completely informed and I will have teams on standby,” Apollo said. And he would too, because he really had reached out to all the proper agencies and told them that there would be a test occurring at AHC headquarters.

After all, doing these drills required purposely tripping a lot of AHC alarms, and he’d hate for rescue workers to mistakenly show up for an emergency that wasn’t happening. Why, he’d hate it almost as much as he’d hate for Lodestar or Professor Quantum to show up for an attack that actually *was* happening. When the alarms sounded and the barriers rose, both of them would take it for nothing more than the practice session they’d been briefed on, effectively removing them from the game board.

They were too powerful, too careful. For this plan to work, there would have to be a wake of destruction, the sort that made the citizens demand an appropriate response from their superheroes.

\* \* \*

Tori flipped through the files she had found on the car seat, skimming through them yet again for some hint at what was to come. After a weekend of apartment-hunting with Beverly (the guild, as it turned out, did have some real estate holdings, but they were limited in availability) and plotting out things like the cost of a new motorcycle and moving expenses, Tori had very nearly forgotten Ivan's request to return to his place in her work clothes. She only remembered at the very last minute and raced around her room at the guild to get ready. When she stepped into the robot-piloted car, a little sweaty and unkempt but otherwise put together, she had found the stack of files waiting for her.

As far as she could tell, they were reports from Vendallia, ones she'd turned in to Ivan earlier in the week. Given that she was also dressed like a regular employee, Tori caught the scent of subterfuge and mentally readied herself to play the part of Ivan's assistant once more. She wasn't certain how this was a gift, but decided to see how it all shook out. Ivan never gave instructions without a reason. Tori's curiosity was piqued.

The car whispered into the driveway just as Ivan emerged from the house. On his heels were two other figures. As soon as she saw them, Tori felt the blood in her veins run cold. She was flung back to her first day at Ivan's house when he'd held up a picture of two people and made it clear that there was one line never to be crossed.

Before she could instruct the driver to whip the car around, the door opened and Ivan called out to her.

"Early as always, Miss Rivas." Ivan quickly stepped forward and held out a hand to help her from the vehicle. She took it, struck dumb by the cheerfulness in his voice and the genuine smile on his face. "It's all right, the others will be here soon. Please, let me take those."

Ivan scooped the files out of Tori's hands as the door shut behind her. Suddenly she was staring into two sets of unfamiliar eyes. The kids watched her every move like she was an unfamiliar dog off its leash, and Tori focused on doing her absolute best to make no movement that could even slightly be interpreted as threatening.

"I don't believe you've ever met my children, have you?" Ivan motioned them forward, and both children inched closer to Tori. "Miss

Rivas, this is Rick and Beth. Kids, this is Miss Rivas, she's a friend and colleague from the office. She's also a bit of an early bird, since the meeting doesn't start for another half hour."

At long last, Tori's tongue found the courage to move. She nodded her head much too hard in agreement. "I'm so sorry about that, completely didn't realize how far I'd missed the mark. If you'd like, I can come back."

"Nonsense, your ride is already leaving," Ivan said. And sure enough, the town car was pulling out of the driveway, headed off to wherever the guild sent it next. Hopefully not too far away, though, seeing as she had left a bag in the trunk. "Why don't you go on in and make yourself comfortable while I drop my children off with their mother? I'm sure you'll be fine on your own for a bit. I trust you."

With those words, Tori finally understood what Ivan was trying to do. He was showing her the extent to which she'd earned his trust. He was introducing her to the only things in the world he truly loved, worried, and cared about. That was why he'd had her come home like this, so that there could be a pretext to introduce her to his children.

"I'll try not to eat all of the food," Tori said. She turned to Rick and Beth, taking each by the hand and giving a firm shake. "It's nice to meet you both. Your father is kind of a stick-in-the-mud, but he's not such a bad boss."

Beth giggled. Rick tried to look interested without looking *too* interested, the paradox that was a teenage boy's attempt to grasp the intangible quality known as 'cool'. "Nice to meet you too," Beth said, tone polite as she visibly considered each word before using it. Tori was hardly shocked to see that Ivan had drilled his kids in the importance of manners, even if the older one was resisting.

"Yeah, cool," Rick mumbled. "I mean, it's a pleasure."

"Guess you got your eloquence from your dad," Tori said. This time, Beth laughed outright, and Rick's neck grew flushed. "Nothing wrong with that, though. They say when men of few words talk, everyone listens. And trust me, no one in the office ignores him when your father speaks."

“That’s probably enough of that,” Ivan interjected. He started to herd the kids towards his car. “I need to get them home, and sooner or later, the rest of the staff will be showing up. Kids, say goodbye to Tori.”

“Bye, Tori,” Beth called, her voice somewhere between a yelp and a holler. She also waved as she walked, swinging both hands overhead with no sense of restraint. It was a little surprising to see such uninhibited friendliness in a girl her age—Tori recalled her and her peers losing the quality by the time they’d gotten as old as Beth. At the same time, it was heartwarming, especially in contrast to the stoic men in Beth’s family.

“Goodbye.” Rick’s voice was a touch more clear this time as he and his sister climbed into the back of Ivan’s car. Ivan shut the doors and turned to his former apprentice, the smile that his children had conjured not fading in the slightest.

“Nice kids,” Tori commented. She wasn’t sure what to make of all this, so instead of trying, she decided to just let Ivan take the lead.

“They are. Good, smart, and faithful to a fault.” Ivan looked at the car where his children were waiting. “It’s important to me that they’re familiar with the people I trust, just in case I ever have to use those people to send messages. They’ve known Wade almost since birth, and the woman you know as Morgana for the past five years. Seemed like it was time to widen that circle of trust just a bit.”

“Thank you, Ivan. It means a lot to me that you set this up. But just so we’re clear, there’s not really a meeting going on tonight, is there?”

“Of course not,” Ivan replied.

“Hot damn am I glad to hear that. I’ve got a suit to repair and a gravitational anomaly generator to install.”

Ivan shook his head, but the smile still didn’t dim. “Go get to it, then. I shouldn’t be more than half an hour dropping off my kids. I’ll knock when dinner is ready.”

“You’re the best landlord ever.” Tori turned away as she spoke, not wanting Ivan to catch sight of the slight wave of sadness she wasn’t sure she could hide. Exciting as the idea of living with Beverly was, Ivan really

was a pretty awesome landlord, and she was going to miss living here. But leaving was inevitable. Even if she'd been on the fence about how long to stay before, this meeting had lit a fire under her.

Ivan had a family to protect. He'd taken a big risk by letting her live here at all. The sooner she was gone, the more removed his life would be from the guild, and the safer his kids would be.

No matter how much apartment-hunting it took, this would be the last week she spent living at Ivan's house.

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## Chapter 75

The office was abuzz with activity as Tori and Ivan walked in Tuesday morning. Both registered this anomaly; them not being among the first people in was strange enough, and anything requiring energy before nine, which was typically when everyone had finally brushed the last bits of sleep from their eyes, was nigh unheard of.

They didn't have to wonder what was going on for long, though. Barb from Human Resources, again in her plastic fireman's hat with "Safety Officer" written across the top, soon barreled up to them.

"Ivan, glad you're in a few minutes early." The woman looked almost frantic, stray wisps of brown hair with gray poking up from the under the plastic red hat. "Word just got sent down from the head office: apparently the AHC is testing their defense system and corporate has decided that it makes sense to give everyone a half-day. I need you to spread the word to the whole department as quickly as possible; we're already trying to coordinate with the people who run the car pools and make sure this doesn't throw off anyone's commute."

"Wait, what are the capes doing?" Tori asked.

"A test of their defensive perimeter," Ivan said. "It means they'll turn on their dome to keep people out, cycle through their offensive systems to make sure everything is working, and maybe have a few of their capes try to bust in just to be certain it's all functioning properly. They used to do them once a year, but it's been a while since the last one."

"Which I was thankful for," Barb added. "All buildings within a block of them evacuate, just in case something goes wrong, and traffic becomes a total nightmare as tons of people head to the perimeter to see the show. That's not even including those who somehow miss the message that it's a drill and think Ridge City's superheroes are under attack. Anyway, since the test is scheduled for three, we're officially dismissed at noon so we have time to safely leave the area before things get crazy."

“I will make certain all of my employees are abreast of the situation,” Ivan told her. “I daresay many will be enthused about the time off more than they’ll be bothered by the surprise.”

“Thanks, Ivan. Pass along the word to any other managers you see, please.” Barb was off before the sound of her words had even faded, scampering toward another woman in a suit who was likely about to be brought up to speed.

“Is there anything to worry about?” Tori asked once she was sure Barb was no longer within earshot.

“Doubtful.” Ivan headed toward his office, seemingly unbothered by news of the AHC’s activities. “This really did used to be standard procedure for them. In fact, I think the only reason it fell off was because so few criminals ever get around to trying something as ridiculous as assaulting the AHC base head-on.”

Though Ivan didn’t say it, they both knew exactly why that sort of thing had tapered off. With the guild watching from the shadows, any criminal who would stir things up to such a degree was usually culled long before they built up enough power or confidence to try and take on the capes directly.

“It was inevitable that they’d have to make sure everything still worked right sooner or later,” Ivan continued. “After the scuffle I saw on the news last week when several tough crooks evaded capture, putting on a show of force makes perfect sense. It’s a good way to remind people that while slip-ups happen, the AHC is still a force to be reckoned with.”

They finished the journey into Ivan’s office and he shut the door, freeing them from having to use doublespeak and subterfuge when talking about the AHC. Despite that freedom, Ivan made no attempt to recant his earlier statements. Instead, he just booted up his computer and pulled out his daily schedule, which had been printed the evening before as always.

“We’ll need to rearrange a lot of my meetings for the day; probably best to assume some people will try to press their luck and cut out by eleven.”

“Not if I pin them down as soon as they get through the door,” Tori replied, pulling out her own day-planner to keep track of whatever assignments Ivan doled out. “But... we’re really okay, right?”

“Tori, our situation means that we are never entirely okay. There is always the possibility that something we didn’t see has given way and the peace we currently know is about to come tumbling down. This particular instance gives me no suspicion or need to worry; then again, if it’s part of an attack on us, it would be designed to do exactly that. That said, if you spend your life looking for capes around every corner, it will be a very stressful one. Be prudent, be smart, and leave paranoia behind you if at all possible.”

“Got it.” Tori pulled out her pen and flipped open the day-planner. “Any ideas on what you’re going to do with your afternoon off?”

“Stay here and work, of course,” Ivan replied. “We’re more than far enough away not to be part of the mandatory evacuation, and this will be a blessed opportunity to get ahead on my reports for a change. With no one around to distract me, I may even be able to knock out a week’s worth of work in one lone afternoon.”

“Wow, you sure know how to party.”

“And I suppose you won’t flee home to lock yourself in the basement and work more on your suit?” Ivan had brought Tori’s dinner down to her lab Monday night, only to find her so engrossed in work that she didn’t even notice his arrival. A few hours later he’d found her passed out at her work bench and had carried her upstairs to the couch, hoping she might get at least a few hours of rest.

“Don’t blame me, you’re the one who gave me an awesome new addition to work in,” Tori countered. “And now that I’ve finally finished that part, all I have to do is fix my right gauntlet and I’ll be back at a hundred percent. Assuming I can get it done before I have to meet Donald for coffee.”

“You should brace for disappointment,” Ivan cautioned her. “These tests tend to be ‘all hands on deck’ situations, which means he might not be able to make your date.”



“Not a date, Ivan, just coffee and catching up. And if Donald has to flake, so be it. More time to work on the suit,” Tori said.

Ivan admired the way the idea of a broken arrangement rolled off Tori’s mind so easily. Capes were not the easiest people to care for, be it in a friendly or more advanced capacity. They lived at the beck and call of the people, always most accountable to a world that needed them. The first canceled plans were easy to bear; the thousandth, far less so. That was a lesson she would have to learn on her own, however. No combination of words would be enough to impart such wisdom. Some things, some pain, had to come firsthand before they stuck.

“The suit will have to wait until this afternoon. With the few hours we have, I plan to cram in as much productivity as possible,” Ivan said.

Tori clicked the top of her pen, dragged a test line of ink across the top of her planner, and looked up with a hungry grin. “Give me the orders, boss. I’m ready.”

\* \* \*

“Everyone understands their order, correct?” Four figures stood before Balaam, four carefully selected members of the guild. Out of everyone, only these four had been deemed capable enough, trustworthy enough, to participate in such a crucial step of the plan. Here, betrayal would mean utter failure, and the death of every person currently standing in the bare, heavily-warded room where Balaam had gathered them.

Their meeting place was not as grand as the executive break rooms inside the guild; in fact, it was downright squalid. An abandoned gas station, long ago given to neglect, was where Balaam chose to have this final meeting. Aside from the fact that such delicate issues couldn’t be discussed inside guild walls, Balaam rather enjoyed the squalor. It reminded him of the old days when he was on the run, taking shelter in whatever hole might conceal his presence for a few hours. Yes, he greatly preferred the luxury of his guild quarters and had no desire to actually lie down and make a home in such a place, but just for visiting, it wasn’t so bad.

“I handle the girl.” This voice was thick and heavy, not unlike the scaled head that spoke it. Rust Tooth was a wide man whose body was

completely coated in dull, bronze-colored scales. A bit of misfortune in a lab that was trying to fuse organic and biological components had created more than one cape along with the savage creature standing before them.

“That’s right,” Balaam agreed. “Use the charms I provided to break the barriers around Pseudonym’s home. They will take a few moments to work, so be prepared for her to expect a fight.”

“Lucky for me, I don’t burn, and I’m a lot tougher than any tin can,” Rust Tooth replied.

“Which is why you’ve got that job, after which you need to meet up with the others,” Balaam replied. “Bombastic, what about you?”

“First the mayor’s office, then the bus stations, then the kids.” This voice came from a small wiry man who had the edges of a thick mustache sticking out from under his mask. “But for now, I just get in place. No moves until you send the signal.”

“Correct,” Balaam agreed. “Torkak and Endless Blitz, once Bombastic kicks things off, it will be on you to lead the attack. Use your forces to overwhelm as many as possible, make sure they know exactly what’s going on. Rust Tooth will join you when he’s finished tying up a loose end.”

A humanoid creature with orange skin, an oversized head, and hands that had seven fingers gave Balaam a nod. Next to it, a regular-looking woman who could have blended in at a boating convention also signaled her agreement. However, along with that signal came a comment.

“Just one thought,” said Endless Blitz. “You’ve been telling us what we’re doing, but what about the rest of the guild? Specifically the council.”

“The rest of the guild will be caught completely off guard,” Balaam assured her. “I have taken all the necessary steps to ensure that any members of the council who might actually be able to interfere are dealt with. What you see here is only one subset of the team preparing for today’s events. There are others, all working separately so that even if one of you falls, the rest may still see us win victory today.”

“I don’t even care if we win or lose anymore,” Rust Tooth growled. “I just want a fight. I’m sick of this fucking peace and the ridiculous code. We’re villains. It’s time we got to act like it.”

“And you will,” Balaam agreed. “In only a few hours we will redeem our entire guild for the past decade of subservience and inaction. By the time the sun falls this evening, that ludicrous peace will be destroyed, and we will all finally be true villains once more.”

\* \* \*

“Now remember: when the dome goes up, getting in or out of the base will be nearly impossible,” Apollo said. He stood on a catwalk overlooking the hangar where most of the AHC’s current personnel had gathered. Next to him, silently scanning the faces of the collected superheroes for any signs of confusion, was Quorum. If he saw too many, he’d have Apollo repeat the order, but otherwise, Quorum preferred to remain quiet during such meetings. Before he’d let Lodestar and Professor Quantum take the reins, so leaving the speech to Apollo was a natural transition.

“That means I don’t want to hear anyone saying they left a tool or a piece of costume inside,” Apollo continued. “We’re going to be outside, but we are far from off-duty. All of our communication and tech people will still be in here, and if a situation arises where you’re needed, we expect you to follow orders. Now, some of you have been taken off the response call list because we’re going to need people to test the defenses, as well as perform crowd control. This is a big undertaking, and it’s easy to let things get out from under us, so I want everyone sticking to their orders. Don’t worry about what you see someone else doing: making a machine like this work takes a whole lot of different cogs.”

Of course, some of those cogs would be off keeping the peace while others would be ensuring that the unseen part of today’s activities ran smoothly. Finding others who felt the same as Apollo hadn’t been hard; the challenge came from selecting the ones he knew he could trust. Things would unfold quickly; if anyone dropped their ball or started telling tales when the dust settled, everything could come undone. That was why he’d

taken his time, been careful, built up to this moment slowly. He needed his cogs to be diligent so that everything would run properly.

At least, until the machine was supposed to self-destruct.

“As a reminder, all of our new members, debuted or not, are on crowd control near the base. Those of you more experienced staff also assigned to that task, be sure to help them when they need it. We all know a few people will try to slip by the perimeter to get a better look, and while we certainly can’t let civilians endanger themselves, we also can’t be too rough when we escort them out. Those of you coordinated into teams, look out for each other. Finally, everyone on crowd control should be prepared for anything. With this many of us out there, only a suicidal idiot would try something, but we’ve seen that sort rear their heads before.”

Cyber Geek, Medley, and Cold Shoulder were staring up at him, admiration in at least two sets of eyes. It was a shame; Apollo might have liked to have used them today, but they were too green and unpredictable. His cogs had to work flawlessly. Still, if they performed well, they might make an excellent media tool for rebuilding the public’s trust: innocent babes, scrambling into action and doing their best. He needed to incorporate the final member before things kicked off. She’d nicely round out the pictures and video that would no doubt be all over the news when things were done.

“All right, we’ve only got a few hours to finish prepping, so everyone get your work done. If you have questions, come find me, and if you’ve got briefings, attend them. As long as we all work together, this day will go off without a hitch.” A small cheer met Apollo’s words, and he replied to it with an appropriately polite smile.

It was funny, in a way. That whole speech and he hadn’t told a single lie. He just hadn’t elaborated on what, exactly, they were trying to pull off without a hitch. They would thank him later, though, the ones that survived and understood. They would thank him for finally making them true heroes once again, for no longer abiding the known existence of evil, even if it hid behind secrecy, bureaucracy, and lawyers. Today, the Alliance of Heroic Champions would once again live up to their name and duty.

Today, they would purge the world of that nest of villains that called itself a guild.

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## Chapter 76

“A pleasure to meet you all. Please, call me Hat Trick.” The young woman in front of Donald, Irene, and Ren took a long bow, giving a bit too good of a view down the cleavage of her tight black blazer. Her hand effortlessly plucked a top hat from her head as she made her gesture, adding a level of formality that would have been out of place even if they weren’t all gathered in a small meeting room.

Aside from the blazer and hat, she wore dark pants that shimmered as though they’d been dipped in glitter, a dark cape with red lining that fell halfway down her back, and a white shirt that poked out from the edges of the dark blazer but did nothing to obscure what was obviously an intentional view of her chest. She was quite pretty as well; red lipstick accentuated her pale skin, and an infectious smile was nicely offset by the smattering of freckles across her face. As she rose, the hat danced between her fingers before settling on her head once more, cocked slightly at a jaunty angle.

“I’m Donald, but I go by Cyber Geek,” Donald said. “This is Ren, aka Medley, and Irene, who goes by Cold Shoulder.”

“Ah, well, in my more mundane hours, I go by Lucy,” Hat Trick replied.

“Lucy Donovan is a great asset. We’ve been looking for just the right team to fit her in with,” Jessica said, jumping in for the first time since she and Barney had called everyone into the room. “During that freak storm some while back, it seems a bolt struck a beginner’s magic kit. Lucy bought it a couple of weeks later, and when she opened it up, poof!”

“The cheap garb and plastic toys were replaced by true implements of the arcane arts,” Lucy explained. “They bonded to me, making me a conjurer whether I wanted to be or not.”

“Now, Hat Trick isn’t quite as strong a combatant as you three,” Barney cautioned them. “But last week’s fight showed us how badly you

need few support member to round things out. And there, Hat Trick has got you covered.”

“My hat functions as a transportable miniature dimensional pocket.” Lucy pulled the hat off again and stuck her hand in, her arm going far deeper than the fabric should have allowed. “Case in point: last night I left a soda in here. And now, TADA!” She pulled out a can and tossed it to Ren, who easily snagged it out of midair.

“Still cold,” Ren noted.

“Exactly. It keeps things as they are when they enter, which makes it perfect for storing tools and weapons, even the sort that need special care.” Lucy flipped the hat back on to her head. From nowhere, a deck of playing cards appeared, bridging and arching through Lucy’s deft hands. “My cape allows me to cast illusions on myself, these cards are functionally unlimited and can be shaped by will, and there are rings that will hold almost anyone in place—”

“What about the wand?” Donald asked, unable to keep himself from interrupting. Ren and Irene stared at him; he flushed but managed to stammer out an explanation anyway. “Oh, come on. Everyone knows magic kits come with wands, don’t act like I’m the weirdo.”

“I... I haven’t quite mastered the wand,” Lucy admitted. Her shuffling faltered. She tucked the deck back up her sleeve, where it seemed to vanish. “I’m working hard on it; I just haven’t been cleared for using it in the field yet. But I’ve got plenty of other tricks, and I promise to do my absolute best.” Her red lips grew smaller as she nervously chewed on the bottom one, glancing between the team and Jessica as if she were afraid she might be turned away.

For the first time, Donald actually wondered if they even *could* turn a new team member away. Apollo had said he wanted them to focus on teamwork, so if they all agreed she wouldn’t be a good fit, he might find them a new one. Not that Donald could imagine being so heartless as to kick Lucy away. The only way he’d be that cruel was if she turned out to be a liability in the field. He started to welcome her but got beaten to the punch.

“Glad to have you aboard, Lucy,” Irene said. She took the newer woman’s hand and gave it a good shake, eliciting a squeal of joy from Lucy, along with a hug that left Irene looking as though she regretted stepping within range of embracing.

“Thank you, thank you, thank you! I’ll really try so hard, and I’ll do whatever it takes to help keep people safe.” Lucy released Irene and grabbed Ren, who was visibly taken aback by the sudden hug. Ever since his transformation, no one had enthusiastically touched him, especially not when he was without the human-illusion as was the case now. When Lucy let go and embraced Donald, Ren patted his chest, almost like he was confused by the warmth she’d left behind.

“We’re all happy to have you,” Donald managed to eke out, despite the impressive amount of force Lucy put into her hugs. “And today’s a good day to start. All we need to do is work crowd control.”

“Consider yourself lucky,” Irene told Lucy. “My first outing with this group involved fighting four criminals robbing a museum.” Both Donald and Ren noticed that she spoke of the event like it had happened years ago instead of just last week. Neither made a point of calling her on it though, both because it would have been bad form, and because she was clearly getting a kick out of not being the newest member on the team anymore.

“Let the rest of us get into costume, then we’ll head out and start setting up barricades and making sure people know they have to go,” Donald said. “The quicker we move, the better a job we’ll do, and hopefully the shorter this whole drill will run.”

“Don’t mind Donald,” Irene said. “He’s just got a hot date later tonight that he’s hoping to make.”

“It’s coffee with a friend,” Donald protested. “But I would like to avoid canceling, so everyone get your butts in gear.”

“Can do!” Lucy saluted, accidentally knocking the hat from her head. It tumbled to the ground, where, upon landing, it spat out two remote control race cars and a half-eaten sandwich. Lucy’s eyes grew wide as she stared at the spilled contents, her mouth opening and closing as she



searched for words. “I promise, it doesn’t fall off if I’m paying attention!” was all she managed to come up with.

“Just make sure you’re paying attention once we’re outside the building,” Donald instructed her. “We want to do our part to keep things running smoothly.”

Lucy nodded vigorously as she bent down and scooped the two cars back into the hat. The sandwich she chunked into a nearby trash can. Much as Donald wanted to ask why she was using a magical pocket dimension to carry that kind of thing, he’d been around other meta-humans long enough to know that the answer probably wouldn’t explain much. If anything, it would just leave him more confused.

Instead, he turned his attention to things he could make sense of, like completing this drill, and hopefully still making it in time for coffee with Tori.

\* \* \*

Chloe stared out the window of Ridge City Grinders, counting the people who walked by. There had been a bit of a rush around noon when several of the nearby offices let out—Tori was seen leading the pack before hopping into a town car—but in the past hour, the streets had grown deserted. Everyone had either run home to avoid the crowds or was gathered up near the AHC headquarters to watch them test their defenses. None of them were bothering to stop for coffee, though.

“Todd, if you want to go, you can,” Chloe called to the only other person still in the store with her. “Meredith comes on in an hour, but I think I can handle things until then.”

“It is a little slow,” Todd agreed. He finished wiping off a table he’d already cleaned twice and threw his rag into the small bucket behind the counter. “What if we get hit by a rush, though?”

“The whole town is either grouped up in one spot or avoiding downtown like we just had an Ebola outbreak. Until they finish up, I’ll be surprised if we get five customers, let alone a rush.” Chloe swept her arms

up, waving them around at the store completely devoid of customers. “Pretty sure I can manage this giant crowd all on my own.”

“You could always close up,” Todd suggested. “Just make it a half-day like everyone else.”

“It’s tempting, but sooner or later, the AHC will finish and all those people trekking back to their cars may want to wait out traffic with a few cups of coffee,” Chloe said. Besides, Tori had mentioned she and Donald might be stopping by around five. It would be nice to visit with her friends. Chloe liked her coworkers and the few people from her life before the accident, but they and Beverly were the only other meta-humans she knew. It would be nice to talk with people who understood. Although, she’d have to remember not to mention Tori’s powers around Donald, since he was still in the dark about them.

“If you’re sure, then I think I will cut out early.” Todd reached up and undid his apron’s knot behind his back, loosening the dark cover. “I wanted to go watch the capes fight their own tech, anyway.”

“You Judas. I let you off and you go to see the very thing that’s stealing all our customers.” Chloe crossed her arms and stared at her coworker. “I expect you to at least take video of the cool stuff and send it over so I can be entertained.”

“I’m on a last gen phone, so it’ll be fuzzy, but I’ll do the best I can,” Todd said.

“Better than sitting around talking to myself, which is probably what I’m going to do five minutes after you leave,” Chloe admitted.

“You’re the only one I know who prefers it when this place is crazy.” Todd hung his apron on a plastic hook just inside the employee break room, then untucked his white shirt from the black slacks they were all forced to wear.

“I’m a child of chaos, and I prefer to be in my element. Today I will have to content myself with the quiet, though.”

Todd headed to the door and pushed it outward, triggering the soft bell that tinkled overhead. “Don’t be so gloomy, there’s always the chance

that things will get exciting later on.”

“It would be nice, but I won’t count on it.” Chloe generally would have said she wasn’t going to hold her breath, however her mind purposely steered away from such well-tread words these days. Bit by bit, she was getting better at coping with her ability. In a way, she couldn’t wait for Donald and Tori to arrive so she could show them how much she’d accomplished.

Sadly, until then it was going to be a whole lot of nothing but boredom and dullness. She pulled out her phone and began to surf the net, desperate to make the hours fly by just a little bit faster.

\* \* \*

It was a nice neighborhood, the sort where he’d smashed out windows and robbed back when he was human. Ordinarily it would be nearly deserted at this time of day, as all the respectable people with their nice little jobs scurried about in their offices, leaving their possessions unguarded. Thanks to the AHC test, however, he could see signs of occupation in at least half of the nigh-identical houses. He could even smell the ones who’d been outside recently, though his nose wasn’t nearly as powerful when he was outside the water.

His old, beat-up car looked out of place amid the shiny new models parked in their driveways. Even though he’d pulled in enough cash doing guild work to trade up, Rust Tooth still preferred the classic American builds that were all steel and smoke. Part of it was aesthetic but the rest was pragmatism. There were only so many vehicles in production that could accommodate a creature of his size. And he counted himself lucky—people like Thuggernaut had to get custom vehicles made.

Counting the numbers on the houses as he passed them, Rust Tooth finally found the one he was looking for. Balaam had given him the call earlier; Pseudonym’s apprentice had been seen on satellite going inside. While Rust Tooth never would have dreamed of trying to break into the legendary villain’s home if he were there, Balaam had assured Rust Tooth that this errand would be uninterrupted. It was just him and a wet-behind-the-ears rookie.

The car groaned as Rust Tooth emerged from it, creaking in joy as it was freed from his weight. He stood on the curb a few inches from where he'd parked and took in the tranquility of the scene before him. If Balaam hadn't given him the address, Rust Tooth would have never imagined that Pseudonym, the man who'd once been feared on an international level, lived here. Then again, that was what made it a good hiding place.

From the back seat, Rust Tooth pulled a black leather bag. Inside were a variety of potions, charms, and tools that would supposedly cut through the wards protecting the place. Even standing at the edge of the property, Rust Tooth could feel the energy pushing him away. It was probably unnoticeable to the normal people living here, only activating when one approached with ill-intent.

There was no getting around that one, though, which was why Balaam had sent those tools. Rust Tooth had come here with the worst possible intentions. He'd come to harm, to destroy, to steal a life that wasn't his. Rust Tooth was here to kill Pseudonym's apprentice. If that didn't trigger the wards, nothing would.

He yanked out a knife that was covered in runes and stabbed the air in front of him, piercing a magical red wall that suddenly appeared where the knife made contact. His wide, inhuman mouth grinned, showing all those worn, serrated, metallic teeth.

The revolution had finally begun.

## Chapter 77

The ear-splitting scream nearly made Tori drop her gauntlet, which would have been extra infuriating since she'd just finished putting a new concentrating lens in place. Her mind raced as the sound drilled into her ears. What in the living hell could cause this? It was too powerful, too focused for it to be a fire alarm. Those echoed and didn't attack the eardrums like targeted missiles. No, this was magic, pure and simple, and that meant there was only one likely candidate for a cause: Ivan's wards.

No sooner had the thought crossed her mind than the sound lessened. It was still there, a high-pitched whine in the back of her head, but apparently the mere act of understanding had taken the edge off its attack. Something was attacking the house, someone powerful enough to actually trip Ivan's magical warning system. But that was crazy, wasn't it? Who in their right mind would attack the home of the man who'd once been Fornax? This must be some sort of hiccup in the system.

As her doubt increased, the sound grew shrill once more, forcing her to put her hands over her ears, though it didn't help. Did that mean something really was attacking? At that thought, it fell back to a mere whine, and Tori slowly lowered her hands from her ears.

"Guess that means it's definitely an attack," she muttered. Of course Ivan would build his wards not to allow for the possibility of self-delusion. But if someone was attacking, they should have been repelled. For the wards to screech like this probably meant a breach was imminent. She needed to brace for a fight, though whether it was with a cape, a crook, or even a fellow guild member remained to be seen. None of the options made sense, but neither did someone attacking Ivan's home in the first place. Logic was going to have to take a back seat until the dust cleared; there were more pressing concerns than why. Namely who was doing this, and how was she going to beat the hell out of them for it.

Tori looked at her meta-suit spread out on the work table before her. There were no sounds of destruction coming from above, so the house

probably hadn't been breached yet. If she hurried, she might be able to gear up before the attackers arrived. But that could mean getting pinned in the basement with no way out—not an ideal situation if she had to make a run for it. Dawdling about trying to make a decision was the worst option she had, though; it burned time while accomplishing nothing.

Someone was breaking in to Ivan's house. The only question was whether or not they'd find Tori waiting to meet them or Hephaestus.

\* \* \*

"You're more mild-mannered than I expected."

Ivan looked up from his paperwork, surprised to see two silhouettes standing in his doorway. The larger man, a gruff fellow with a thick beard and a giant gun strapped to his back, had been the one to speak. Meanwhile, the woman dressed in all black and somehow not quite as well-lit stood silently, watching him, waiting to react if he tried anything.

"My goodness, Blunderbuss and Lady Shade, what brings two such beloved superheroes to the offices of Vendallia Industries? If you want a tour, I'm afraid most of the staff is gone for the day, although I'm sure your office can set something up for later in the week with proper notice." Ivan carefully set his pen down on the desk, being certain not to make any aggressive motions. Bad as this looked; it didn't mean the situation was unsalvageable. If punches began to fly, that could likely no longer be said.

"We're not here for the tour, or for the offices, or even for you, Ivan, since that's what you go by these days. We're here to pick up Fornax," Blunderbuss said, all but spitting the last word on Ivan's carpet.

"Fornax, you say? I can't imagine you'd find him here." Ivan knit his hands together on the desk, keeping them in plain view the whole while. "In fact, I doubt you'd find him anywhere. Fornax ceased to be a legal entity on the day Orion was defeated. There are no warrants for him; all those were expunged when he stopped existing. So, if you've come here to arrest Ivan Gerhardt, I would like to see the warrant, know the charges, and speak to my lawyer. However, if you've come seeking Fornax, I'm afraid I can't help you."

“He’s being glib, can you believe that?” Blunderbuss looked to Lady Shade, who didn’t answer him or react to Ivan’s words in any way. She was on edge, a single quick motion away from attacking. Personally, Ivan hoped it didn’t come to that. Two dead capes would be a pain to deal with.

“How many times has that little speech kept you out of the cell where you rightfully belong?” Blunderbuss continued. “If it’s even once, that’s one too many by my count. But today, it ain’t happening. You’re coming with us to face justice, right here and now.”

“Is that so?” Ivan pushed back his chair—the squeak caused Lady Shade to twitch—and slowly rose to his feet. “It seems I should remind you that while the Alliance of Heroic Champions has some leeway in dealing with imminent threats to property and civilians, they do require actual warrants for arresting suspects not actively posing a threat. Trying to take me in without one is illegal, unconstitutional, and I am fully within my rights to resist such an arrest. I would urge you both to follow proper channels if you’re truly set on seeing this course of action through.”

“Quite scary when you’ve got red tape to hide behind,” Blunderbuss shot back. “But there’s not going to be a fight. You’re going to come with us nice and peacefully. You won’t even so much as ask for a lawyer again.”

“Really?” Ivan arched an eyebrow in curiosity. “And may I ask why I would do such a thing?”

“Thirteen forty-four Maplebark Lane.” Blunderbuss barely whispered the words yet Ivan felt a shock run all the way through his body. He glanced from the stout man with the giant gun to the woman surrounded by swirling shadows, no longer merely annoyed by their antics. Now, he could feel the beginnings of rage starting to press at the backs of his eyes.

The address Blunderbuss had just given was of the school where both of Ivan’s children should currently be in class.

“I see. Are you absolutely certain you want to go down this road? It’s not very heroic. Not even my people would stoop so low.”

“It’s for the greater good,” Blunderbuss replied. “Just an insurance policy, to make sure you don’t get out of hand. As long as you cooperate,

nothing will happen.”

Despite the powerful, almost intoxicating urge to leap forward and slowly choke the life from the bearded man’s throat, Ivan held his calm and gave a short nod. He stepped around his desk and approached them, standing only inches away.

“I want to assure you of something. I don’t know what your plan is or what sort of game you’ve made me a pawn in, but I promise you right here and now that you are going to regret this decision. I don’t care if it costs me my secret, my freedom, or even my life, I will personally ensure that you look back at this as the greatest mistake either of you has made in your entire lives.” Ivan took no threatening steps toward them. He didn’t even raise his voice. It took every ounce of his self-control to keep his eyes normal, though. The power inside him was burning, his anger fueling it by the second. Only the thought of Rick and Beth kept his rage at bay. Until they were safe, he would stay in control.

“Is that it? I’m a superhero. I have scum like you threaten me six times a day,” Blunderbuss said.

Ivan stared down at the cape’s surly face and his thick, knotted muscles. No doubt he was a tough fighter, one who had a lot of confidence. But he was still young; he hadn’t been around for the glory days of villainy before the guild started purging the biggest threats before they could reach him.

Leaning slightly down to emphasize the height difference between them, Ivan lowered his voice and let out a whisper that was almost a hiss.

“You have *never* met a monster like me.”

\* \* \*

The last of the magic finally gave way, and Rust Tooth set a clawed foot onto Ivan Gerhardt’s lawn. It had taken almost ten minutes to punch a hole in the defenses, and in that time, he’d seen several of the neighbors peeking out through their windows. The black trench coat covering Rust Tooth’s body did a poor job of concealing the beast inside, and the long tail poking out the bottom certainly didn’t help matters. Even if they didn’t



know what he was doing, someone—likely a few of them—had definitely called the cops by now. That was fine; Balaam had told him not to bother with stealth. In fact, the more people that saw him, the better. The police would be tied up by the AHC’s defense test, and even if they made it before he left, it would just be more bodies on the pile.

Rust Tooth tore off his coat as he ran toward the house. He wanted to be seen in his full, terrifying glory. He wanted the rookie to look upon the face of her death and despair. She was a disciple of a whipped dog, the sort of weak-minded person who’d dragged the guild down from what it could have been. He was going to enjoy tearing her apart, sending a message to everyone who thought villains should live on the sidelines. The front door loomed before him, but with no more magic to get in the way, it might as well have already been made of splinters. And that’s what Rust Tooth turned it into as he barreled through.

He’d barely gotten a step inside before a half-dozen small *pings* echoed off his torso. Looking down, Rust Tooth saw a cluster of needles, all bent or snapped in half, which had fallen at his feet. Across the room, slowly lowering her left arm, was Pseudonym’s apprentice. She was dressed in her armor again, but Balaam had already given Rust Tooth plenty of warning about that. It might be useful, but the girl was no Doctor Mechaniacal. Her suit couldn’t stand up to a barrage of attack from a meta-human like him. Especially since she wasn’t able to hurt him back.

“I know you.” The voice wasn’t feminine as it crackled through the dark helmet, but Rust Tooth knew it was her inside. “I’ve seen you at the guild. You were at the membership ceremony on Friday. Why in the hell are you attacking Pseudonym’s house?”

Rust Tooth was almost, *almost*, tempted to try and play at subterfuge. Tell her that Pseudonym had been attacked and that no one had a way inside, so he was sent to warn her. But he quickly realized anyone smart enough to build a meta-suit would probably see through any story he could whip together. Besides, he wanted her to die knowing what was happening, the fate her teacher had earned for her.

“My name is Rust Tooth, and I’m here because the guild is experiencing a change in management,” Rust Tooth told her. “And as part

of that, we're taking care of anyone who might cause problems under the new regime. Since you're the apprentice of that dog, you're being put down too."

"Hoo boy, I really want to believe you're joking, but if you're breaking in here, I guess you can't be," she said. "Are you stupid? I mean, really, *really* stupid? Some morons in the guild decided to try and stage a coup, and *you* volunteered to piss off Pseudonym? Your best case scenario here—and I mean utter best case—is killing me and getting away, at which point, he will murder the living shit out of you for it."

"Pseudonym isn't Fornax," Rust Tooth growled. He wanted to crush all her hopes before he crushed her body. It wasn't practical, but it *was* villainous, and by the gods, it felt so good to finally be a real villain again. "Not anymore. He's gotten soft. Grown weak. While he might still have the power, he's no longer unassailable. He created his own vulnerabilities."

There was a moment of near silence, the only sound in the house the settling of a few bits of debris raining down from the shattered doorframe. While Rust Tooth couldn't see her face through the helmet, he could imagine the shock and terror filling her eyes as she realized that her precious teacher wasn't coming to save her. Soon there would be whimpering, and then begging, and only then would he get the full satisfaction of killing her as she cried for her life.

"His kids." It wasn't a whimper at all; in fact, Rust Tooth was shocked at how much fury managed to make it through the garbling of her helmet. "You're threatening Ivan's kids. God. Damn. You people are *fucking* idiots. Do you have any idea what will happen if you hurt them?"

"I think you should be more concerned about yourself, little apprentice." She wasn't playing along, and it was beginning to take some of the fun out of this for Rust Tooth. If she wasn't going to give him a satisfying, weepy death, then he'd just hurry things along. Maybe one of the neighbors would be a bit more compliant.

"You're the one that should be worried. You should be praying to every god you know that I kill you, because it's the only way you're getting spared from Ivan's wrath. And one more thing..."

In a single motion, she hunched forward, and with a flare from behind her, she barreled into Rust Tooth's chest, arms crossed in an X formation in front of her to strike as many ribs as possible.

The force of the impact sent Rust Tooth flying back into a wall, which buckled under his weight. She didn't let up as they crashed, slamming a fist into his right ribs and then flexing the fingers on her left hand. From the tip of each came a two-inch, focused flame burning white-hot.

"I'm not an apprentice anymore. The name's Hephaestus, motherfucker." With that, she jammed her miniature torches right into Rust Tooth's face.

## Chapter 78

“And as soon as the authorization goes through... and look, there it is. Everything is officially in motion,” Apollo announced, pointing to a light on the screen that had switched from red to green. “We’ve set all the defense systems to activate but left in the lower-tier override.” Without that stipulation, it would require three members of the Champions’ Congress to deactivate the system, but this way, either he or Quorum could do it once the test was done.

The two of them were in the deepest layer of the AHC’s sub-basement where the terminals that oversaw the security system were housed. It had taken over an hour and both of their authorizations, but they’d finally gotten everything properly set up for a test of the base’s defenses. Quorum typed a few more bits of code on his keyboard, then hit enter and stood up from his terminal.

“Only forty-five minutes until the system turns on,” he announced. “Do you need to do any more checks with the teams?”

“No, I’ve left everything in the hands of our operators,” Apollo replied. “We can’t count on any one superhero taking the lead during an attack; what if every member of the Congress is already in the field? Better to drill them using the operators to coordinate, just like we’d have to in a real attack.”

“Then all that’s left is for us to get out of here.” Quorum moved for the door, and Apollo was only a few steps behind. They passed a variety of instruments, some confiscated off of criminals and mildly dangerous (the truly restricted ones were tucked behind yet another layer of security), others little more than clutter that had been moved down here for convenience.

Beyond the various devices, just before the elevator they’d ridden down, were a set of three cells. These were the original holding areas constructed before an entire floor was created specifically as a makeshift, temporary prison. Each was empty, as the AHC only used its cells to hold

prisoners while proper facilities were established, but they were a sight to behold. Forged from a composition of metals Professor Quantum refused to share details on, all of them were lined with a myriad of runes designed to dampen magical powers, wired to disable anyone who tried to break free, anchored to stop all teleportation or space tunneling, and strong enough to withstand attacks from anyone short of Lodestar.

Apollo paused in front of one, looking into the well-lit depths, wondering just how many villains had been tossed into it over the years. Not enough, he knew that much for certain. There was a whole guild that deserved to have seen the inside of these rooms. It was a shame that they'd been retired, but as the AHC grew, so did its needs. Besides, it didn't make a lot of sense to store criminals in the same room as the security system, no matter how good the cells were. Only Professor Quantum had that level of arrogance, and it hadn't taken long for Quorum and Lodestar to convince him of the error once they'd joined on. Apollo knew that and a thousand other tidbits of history about the organization he'd just reached the top of. He'd studied the AHC's history tirelessly because he genuinely loved what it did and what it stood for. That was what made learning about the blind eye they turned toward the guild all the more infuriating.

"Checking out the old handiwork?" Quorum asked, stepping to Apollo's side.

"They're still pretty impressive," Apollo said. "I bet we could use them, if we really had to."

"Those would be desperate times," Quorum replied. "You think we skimped on the protocol for the outer defenses? Since these aren't sanctioned for use, they haven't been checked over in decades."

"Actually, they just got a tune-up yesterday." Without any more warning than that, Apollo grabbed Quorum by the shoulder and gave him a powerful shove. It would have thrown most people right into the wall at the back of the cell and likely turned them to pulp in the process, but Quorum was barely inside before he killed his momentum and spun around.

It was too little, too late, however, as a barrier of energy now separated him from Apollo, the elevator, and the outside world as a whole.

To Apollo's surprise, Quorum seemed unfazed by the sudden twist in their situation. He merely studied the inside of the cell with a quizzical expression then looked at Apollo. "Interesting."

"Interesting? I have to admit, I was expecting a little bit more of a reaction," Apollo said.

"Apollo, I have the minds of over a thousand people inside me; at least of few of them are better liars than you. I've known for over a year you had some plan of betrayal in the works, I just didn't think it would be this simple," Quorum replied. "If your goal is to keep me penned up in here and lock the rest of the Congress out of the system, I should tell you upfront that it won't work. And unless you made serious modifications to the cells, there's nothing lethal inside, which means that if you want to kill me, you'll have to come do it by hand."

The threat hung in the air, the old superhero and the young cape separated only by a barrier that not even they were powerful enough to break through. Rather than rising to it, Apollo merely shook his head in disappointment.

"I'm not going to kill you, Quorum. I just need to keep you out of the way for a few hours. I don't want to take over the AHC; I want to fix its biggest mistake. Your generation grew old and lazy. You let a nest of vipers live in your city, giving them leeway because they killed smaller rats and hid in the shadows. When this is all over, you can try to kick me out of the Congress, but it might not be that easy. Think long and hard while you're down here: do you want to be one of the brave superheroes that reacted to a heinous attack by a guild of shadow villains, or will you tell everyone that you ignored their presence until I locked you down here and forced the issue? Whichever story you choose, Quorum, I'll back. All you have to do is live with the consequences."

Apollo pressed the button to call the elevator, turning his back to Quorum and the cell. The older cape stared at him, remembering when Apollo had first come in, shining with determination and the desire to make the world a better place. Those traits were still there, but they'd been corrupted, warped by time and ambition. He'd seen it happen before, and each instance was a genuine tragedy.

“Do you know why I promoted you, even though I was certain you had some sort of betrayal up your sleeve?” Quorum asked.

“Because I was too essential to lose?” Apollo said. A *ding* filled the room as the elevator opened. Apollo stepped inside.

“No,” Quorum replied. “It’s because I’ve found that the best way to expose traitors is to give them a chance to strike. Once the fangs are bared, there’s no more deception. Today, I’ll roust every one of you from the Alliance.”

“You’re welcome to try,” Apollo said, just as the doors began to slide closed once more. “But forgive me for not waiting. There’s a guild of villains that’s about to start a war with us.”

\* \* \*

Up until a few minutes prior, Hephaestus would have described the battle with Medley as one of her life’s toughest fights. One that, in truth, she hadn’t managed to win, but only escape, thanks to Bahamut’s help. That bar that Medley had set, however, was rapidly being surpassed as Rust Tooth smashed her idea of what a tough battle was to pieces, along with Ivan’s dinner table as he hurled her through it.

She rolled with the attack, coming up on her feet just in time to dodge a swipe from his giant claws. Medley’s claws had been sharp and deadly, true, but they were also relatively small. Rust Tooth may as well have glued steak knives to his fingers as he effortlessly cut through the floor where Hephaestus’s foot had been only a second before. Every bit of him was covered in that greasy, stained metal, including the giant tail that whipped around and caught her in the side as she dodged. She smashed into the kitchen and collided with the refrigerator.

Rust Tooth was strong, tough, armored, armed, and clearly accustomed to combat, yet none of those were what made the situation so problematic. No, the issue was that the son of a bitch seemed almost impervious to fire. Her miniature torches had barely gotten more than a twitch out of him before he shoved her away and began a counterattack. Whatever meta-condition he’d gotten, it was one that had a lot of resistance

to heat, which was no doubt part of why he'd been tasked with eliminating her.

Hephaestus pulled herself up warily, eyes on Rust Tooth as he watched her from the doorway of the kitchen with that predatory smile. While she was mostly incorporeal inside her suit and therefore not getting hurt, the suit itself was taking a beating. She'd designed it specifically to resist the type of bludgeoning damage he was doling out, but if Rust Tooth caught her with one of those claws, her meta-suit would be down at least one limb. And that might be a worthwhile sacrifice to win the fight if she were not now keenly aware that killing her was only one small part of something much bigger. Whatever was happening, she wanted all her tools available for it. But now that she knew Ivan's kids were in danger, she also knew that they couldn't afford for her to draw out this fight much longer.

Or rather, the world might not be able to afford it.

"Thinking about running?" Rust Tooth snickered. He'd mistaken her pause for fear and was gloating in it. "I know you can hop out of that suit whenever you want, turn into fire and scamper away. I know everything about you."

So, he knew she had an escape trump card but was unbothered by it. No doubt he had some sort of countermeasure planned; he had to, given how expertly he'd dispatched Ivan's wards with his arcane toolset. Even only catching the last few minutes of the break-in, Tori had to admit he'd come prepared. Perfectly prepared, in fact. He might be one of the best candidates in the guild to kill her, given his powers, and he'd brought accessories to overcome his lack of magical skill. Every move she'd made, he'd been ready for. Someone had made a plan specifically to murder her, and they knew every tool or trick she might bust out to turn the tides because she'd put them all on display during her apprenticeship.

Except... there might be one they hadn't counted on.

Hephaestus flexed the gauntlet on her right hand, diverting power and starting the charge. Who else knew about the concentrated beam attack? It had been broken during the robbery, and she hadn't been able to bring any inventions into the desert trial. That left Ivan, Xelas, and Doctor Mechanial. Ivan would never have done something like this—if he



wanted to kill her, then he'd be the one to do it—and if either of the others were traitors, then she was probably dead anyway. Ending this fight would take a high-stakes gamble, and after everything her guild training had put her through, she was oddly comfortable with that fact.

Patience wearing thin, Rust Tooth rushed through the doorway to the kitchen, his giant shoulders shattering the drywall on either side. With the beam's charging taking most of her power, Hephaestus wouldn't be able to stand many more direct hits. It was time to engage in the better part of valor. Sparing enough power to engage her flight function for only an instant, Hephaestus leapt through the air, right over Rust Tooth's shoulder, and came down on both feet in the living room. The maneuver caught him by surprise, but as she turned around to gauge his position, she realized that he was unfortunately quick to recover.

In three giant steps, he was back on her, but out here in the living room, she at least had a little room to maneuver. Every attack seemed to be only millimeters away from connecting; her suit was sluggish with almost all her power diverted to the beam. Rust Tooth was toying with her, taking his time to enjoy the kill, otherwise he could have easily turned her suit to scrap. Even that had evidently lost its luster, though. Rust Tooth threw a shoulder into her, knocking her roughly into the stone fireplace. Before she could recover, his tail swept her legs, and in an instant the massive beast had her pinned down by the shoulders.

"I'm disappointed," he growled, his putrid breath washing over the front of her helmet. "I'd expected more from the disciple of Fornax."

As carefully as she could, Hephaestus turned her right hand over, angling her palm so that it was directly facing Rust Tooth's stomach. With those giant hands on her suit's shoulders, she didn't have much maneuverability, but on the upside, it was hard to miss at point blank range.

"It's not over," she said, staring at the top corner of her display, pleading with the universe for a green icon to appear. "I can still jump out of this thing and run. What are you going to do if I warn Ivan that you're attacking his kids?"

"Oh, by now he's keenly aware," Rust Tooth said. "He won't make a single move out of fear for their safety. As for running away... I look

forward to watching you try.”

And of course, he was just smart enough not to tell her what countermeasures were in place. It might be a bluff, but Rust Tooth didn't seem like the wily type. He really did want her to run; he yearned for her to be more vulnerable. Beating up the suit clearly wasn't doing it for him.

“Turning on a guild member, kidnapping children. I can't believe you ever had the nerve to call yourself a villain. You're nothing but a common street thug.”

“After today, no one is going to have that neutered sense of villainy anymore.” Rust Tooth tightened his grip while widening his mouth just a touch. It only took one viewing of a nature documentary to know what was about to happen. “And no one will ever nag us about some stupid goddamned code ever again. Your kind is out of date, and today, you go extinct.”

As Rust Tooth's maw opened, Hephaestus glimpsed what would go down as one of the top ten most breathtakingly beautiful sights of her entire life: a small green dot flickered in the corner of her display. Within the confines of her suit, she grinned maliciously.

“Maybe so, but you'd better believe we'll drag as many of you to hell with us as we can. How about you and I get a head start?”

Hephaestus fired the fully charged beam, flinging Rust Tooth off her body even as the scent of roasting flesh filled the air. The beam carved through him, then the ceiling and the room above, then the roof, finally opening a hole to the sky, which Hephaestus was shocked to see was so gorgeously blue. This felt like the kind of day that should have been cloudy and bleak, but it seemed sometimes monsters lurked even in the sunshine.

Debris from the massive hole she'd blown in Ivan's house began to rain down. Hephaestus rolled out of the way and hurried to her feet. Rust Tooth was ahead of her, scrambling out the broken front door while trying to hold together the remains of his stomach. She'd nailed his left side, but hadn't gotten the shot centered enough to take out his spine. Still, the angry predator had vanished, leaving nothing more than a meta shaped like a metallic crocodile scurrying to escape while keeping his guts inside.

Hephaestus followed, flexing her gauntlet once more to reactivate the charging sequence. Inside the suit, she burned as hot as she dared, feeding the fuel cells while letting off the rage that was bubbling up from within. Now that fear was retreating, Hephaestus was realizing just how livid she truly was. One of her fellow guild members had broken into Ivan's home, his place of safety, and tried to murder her in cold blood. That didn't even touch on the fact that they were going after her teacher's children, or that her friends were likely in just as much danger.

The sounds of wood snapping echoed from behind her. Hephaestus glanced back to see Ivan's house, one of the first places she'd been able to call home in over a decade, collapsing from within. She also noticed the neighbors peering through their windows, no doubt wondering what on earth was going on. It was a Tuesday afternoon in the suburbs; there weren't supposed to be monsters or giant beams blasting into the sky. And now, on top of everything else, it looked like even if Ivan and his kids survived the day, they wouldn't be able to slip back into their civilian lives. One more cherry on the sundae of clusterfuckery that Rust Tooth had brought down on them.

"Hell of a trump card," the monster coughed. In the time she'd looked away, Rust Tooth had fallen to his knees, oily green blood oozing through his fingers as he desperately tried to make sure his insides stayed that way. "Can't believe you didn't use it in the fight with Medley."

"I didn't want to kill Medley." This was true yet skirted the fact that her beam could be broken easily, a design flaw she was now determined to fix at the first opportunity.

"So, to keep a cape safe, you held back when the whole guild was watching and didn't show your best weapon, which almost cost you your victory." Rust Tooth fell forward, taking the landing face-first as his hands stayed wrapped around his side. "And yet you beat me. What the hell kind of villain are you?"

"I'm the patron saint of bad bitches." Hephaestus walked forward carefully, wary of a counterattack, even as injured as her opponent was. She slipped a foot under Rust Tooth's shoulder and flipped him over, eliciting a

groan of pain as he flopped onto his back. “And I want to know what the fuck you’re doing with Ivan’s kids.”

“Kiss my scaly ass,” Rust Tooth coughed. That cough turned into a scream as Hephaestus slammed a foot down onto his hands and the hollowed out chunk of torso he was clinging to.

“We both know you’re already dead,” Hephaestus told him. “You died the minute you stepped on to this property uninvited. Now you get to choose: send me away from here by giving me something else to do, or keep me around so I make your last moments as painful as possible.”

“Or you could end it quickly,” Rust Tooth said, flecks of his blood covering those sharp teeth.

“That’s the sort of thing I might consider for a true villain, one who had a little honor. The sort who would admit they were beaten and give the victor a prize of information.” She didn’t stomp on him again, but she did note that the green dot had reappeared on her display.

“Honor. You fucking noble types. This was our world, a place where the wild and strong lived on top, and then you all came in here with your codes and honor and messed everything up.” Rust Tooth looked up at the sky for several seconds then shook his massive head. “Bombastic is setting off explosives all over the city. The school where Ivan’s kids go, Kelsington Prep, was one of his targets. If Ivan does anything to intervene when the fighting starts, the whole place goes tumbling down.”

“You’re the worst kind of garbage.” Hephaestus raised her gauntlet, took careful aim, then let off a short, controlled blast. When the smoke cleared, there was a scorched ditch burned in Ivan’s yard, right next to a corpse that was curiously absent a head.

Hephaestus looked around the neighborhood once more, noting the distant sound of sirens approaching. She didn’t know if she’d ever get to see this place again, so she meant to savor the view for one precious moment.

Walking over to the bag that Rust Tooth had brought, she examined the contents. All that remained beside the used up trinkets was a modified paintball gun. Taking a cursory look at the ammunition, she wagered they

were designed to fire concentrated blasts of CO<sub>2</sub>, perfect for killing living fire. She slipped the gun into a side compartment of her suit, took one last glance at the neighbors, and then leapt.

Her rear thrusters kicked on as she reduced her weight, sending her blasting into the air. Hephaestus set a course for town, checking the internet for Kelsington Prep's address. She also tried to make some calls. First Ivan, then Beverly, then Donald.

None of them were answering, which only made Hephaestus fly that much faster.

## Chapter 79

“And it is up!”

Cyber Geek turned at the sound of Hat Trick’s voice, eyes going wide as he watched the giant, glowing yellow dome flicker into existence over the AHC’s headquarters. He’d seen countless pictures of this spectacle from tests in years prior and during the few times when someone was actually dumb enough to fight the AHC head-on, but being there in person was a completely different experience. Perhaps it was because he had the scale to appreciate how vast and powerful the dome was; more likely it was because he was no longer looking at the AHC as an outsider. This wasn’t just a demonstration of power: it was his organization’s demonstration of power, and Cyber Geek’s heart swelled with pride as he saw the wowed faces in the crowd around him.

Applause drifted up from the crowd, who pushed forward to get a better view. Bodies pressed against the wooden barricades designed to keep them back. Much as Cyber Geek wanted to stand there and marvel at what was to come, the pride of being part of the AHC came with the cost of duty, and they needed to do theirs.

“Back everyone, back please,” he said, his voice snapping the others out of their own fugues.

Medley didn’t even need to talk; he simply paced the area around the barricades and people shrank back. Cold Shoulder was cooling her zone, making it uncomfortable for anyone to stand too near them. Hat Trick, whom Cyber Geek had been worried about since this was her first time in the field, was doing a marvelous job. She had a sort of clumsy, sweet naiveté that made her requests for people to move away impossible to refuse. Fighting her would have been like arguing with a kitten. Useful as her nature was from a PR standpoint, Cyber Geek was a bit concerned about how it would translate in battle. She’d have the chance to prove herself soon enough, just hopefully not today.

Slowly, they shifted the crowd back as other superheroes moved into position around the glowing dome. This was the part where things could get dicey if any humans were too close by. Testing the AHC's defenses was dangerous even for meta-humans, which was why only those with very powerful, specific skill sets were checking each one. The dome was a last resort, a final line of defense in case someone made it through the more offensive obstacles, and that was exactly what Cyber Geek's peers were about to attempt.

Personally, he was glad his power didn't make the cut. Cool as being on this special task force might be one day, the last few weeks had left him keenly aware of his own limitations. Cyber Geek was in no hurry to stand at a level he wasn't ready for. Crowd control was perfectly fine for the moment. Glory was well and good, but today he would be happy if everything went smoothly and he'd done his part to keep the citizens safe.

\* \* \*

Xelas had never minded when the AHC performed their tests. Personally, she enjoyed anything that drew massive amounts of people to one location because it meant she could avail herself of the locales they'd abandoned. In this case, she was making her way down Quorum Drive, a shopping hot spot renamed decades ago in honor of one of the city's greatest superheroes. Other streets she might have avoided out of principle, but Xelas had met Quorum many times and had no particular quarrel with the man. He'd been kind to her even before she sued her way to freedom. Plus, this street had lots of high-end boutiques, and the only thing more fun than stealing her income was spending it frivolously.

Of course, no one who saw her enter the shops recognized the bubbly blonde as the metallic woman who'd dragged Tech Lord and all his perversion up and down a courtroom. Anonymity was easily one of the best perks of holographic capabilities... that and being able to change her looks to suit her mood.

The distant woman working the counter gave her a compulsory nod of greeting, then ignored Xelas completely. She'd be over in a snap if called, but would otherwise stay out of the way, a trait that Xelas greatly appreciated.

She was examining a lovely silk blouse, her calibrated eyes picking out the telltale signs of handcrafted stitching, when a flood of gasps from her fellow shoppers filled the room. Xelas turned to find a large, mechanical figure standing in the doorway. He—for this one was recognizable and had a gender—stepped into the boutique and stared at Xelas.

“I have been sent to locate you, Xelas.”

“They send the robot to pick up the robot. I’m actually a little offended. It seems like stereotyping, don’t you think?” Her hologram flickered before vanishing entirely, causing a fresh wave of shock to ripple through the customers. “But you’ve got no right to grab me, Stalwart Iron. I’m a free citizen, and everything in these bags is bought and paid for. Overpaid for, if I’m being honest.”

Stalwart Iron turned from her to the woman at the counter. “Please evacuate all shoppers and staff from these premises. If Xelas resists, I fear you might be caught up in her crossfire.”

That was all the prompting the humans needed; they bolted out of the shop so quickly Xelas wondered if a few were secretly teleporters. In seconds, the store was clear, leaving only the two mechanical creations staring at one another.

“What are the charges?” Xelas demanded. “I’d like to know on what false accusations my lawyer will have to sue the shit out of you for.”

“Conspiracy to attack the people of Ridge City and the Alliance of Heroic Champions. We know about the bombs you’ve been setting up and the attempt to strike at the AHC while we are distracted by defense tests. Cough up any information you have and cooperation will be factored into your sentencing.”

“I say this bot to bot: it might be time for your yearly tune-up,” Xelas told him. “I don’t know about any conspiracy, and I certainly don’t give a crap about—”

The explosion was only a few blocks over, so close that it shook the very ceiling above them. Dust cascaded onto the overpriced fabrics she’d been looking at only moments before. News streams lit up as Xelas



accessed the local feed, all showing live footage of a burning government office. The familiar form of Torkak could be seen on camera, his trademark orange skin catching the attention of everyone on the scene. Why was one of her guild members at the scene of a public attack? And how had Stalwart Iron known it was coming?

“If I say I had no idea about any of this, will you believe me?” Xelas asked.

“I am acutely aware of exactly what the truth is,” Stalwart Iron said.

Xelas nodded, activating her combat systems with a single thought. “Then I guess there’s no point in talking.”

\* \* \*

Morgana stared blankly at the television, the news on the screen streaming the same flaming wreckage that half of Ridge City was watching. She had just picked up the phone to call Doctor Mechanical when the sliding door to her balcony shattered inward, sending shards of broken glass scattering to the floor. Moving with an instinct from years of constant combat she’d spent a lifetime honing, Morgana leapt over the granite surface of her kitchen’s island, taking cover behind the structure she’d had reinforced for just such occasions. Seeing as she lived in the top-floor penthouse of a very expensive building, the number of people who could attack her was slightly limited to those who could fly or scale heights. The attacker was probably meta-human. Morgana racked her brain to think if any of her old enemies had resurfaced lately.

“Morgana Le Faye, the Blood Witch, you are hereby under arrest for conspiracy to attack Ridge City and the Alliance of Heroic Champions.” Sounds of a heavy landing and crunching glass followed the words. Morgana glanced up to the pots hanging on the rack above her head and noticed a distinctive green, shiny humanoid shape making its way into the kitchen from the balcony. It paused, looking over at her now slightly off-kilter television screen still displaying footage of the bombing. “It seems I caught you admiring your handiwork.”

“Nice to have company, Erinite, but I’d very much like to see the warrant before I offer you refreshments,” Morgana yelled. Her blood was

pounding in her ears. Normally she took comfort in the sound, but it wasn't offering the usual reassurance in the face of this particular enemy.

"You are free to review any and all documentation once you are adequately restrained and in custody. If you try and resist, I will consider you to be hostile and treat you appropriately." Long jagged shards began to emerge from Erinite's arms. He'd been featured in more than enough thrilling AHC battles for Morgana to know he was getting ready to fire those things directly through her kitchen island. The massive thing would probably stand up to the first set of them—she'd armored it heavily—but afterward, he would change tactics. Erinite was made of living crystal; there was no blood in his veins, or even veins at all. Given Morgana's skill set, he was a... less than ideal opponent.

"Why on earth would I have attacked that building? They are smart enough to send someone like you to get me, so they know I've never used that sort of technique." Morgana didn't actually expect him to listen or to talk her way out of whatever was happening. This was coordinated, an intentional strike meant to catch her off guard. Whoever had masterminded it wouldn't send a person who could be swayed by logic. There was also a good chance Erinite knew damn well she'd had nothing to do with it, which was why he was handling her arrest so forcefully.

No, she wouldn't change his mind, but the repartee would buy her a few seconds of time. Her nails, freshly manicured, raced down her left arm, pressing the sharp tips through her skin. It took longer than she wanted, but finally the first drop of sticky red blood swelled against her flesh.

"You think I don't know that the bombs are only the first step? You're trying to panic the AHC during its tests so you can mount an assault and take us out. If you surrender peacefully and tell me every other aspect of what you've got planned, I might be able to get you a more lenient sentence when the time for a trial comes." Erinite was rising off the ground once more, probably hoping to catch her by surprise.

Blood flowed from Morgana's right arm, quickly hardening into a dark red blade. The room spun for a moment as she was overtaken by a dizzy spell, but she grit her teeth and powered through. She'd lost far more blood than this and still managed to fight, although it was a good reminder

of why she generally avoided using her own blood in combat. Life wasn't always so kind as to cater to one's whims, however, so she set her sights on the green crystal man she could see inching forward in an overhead pot's reflection.

"Sorry, Erinite, but if someone is acting on behalf of my guild, then it's my job to stop them," Morgana whispered. "And I can't let anyone get in the way." With that, she sprang from her position, gaining a half-second of surprise. She used that instant to thrust her blood knife forward, hoping to separate his green head from the neck where it fused to his torso. He blocked the thrust with a sudden growth of crystal from his shoulder, then grabbed Morgana and threw her backward against the oven.

"I take this to mean you will not be coming peacefully," he said.

Morgana dipped her head for a moment, noticing that the attack had opened up several wounds in her back and legs, which were now oozing blood. "Unfortunately, you're spot on." She raised her eyes, meeting the empty green sockets where Erinite's would be were he human. "But any time you're ready to surrender, I'll happily accept."

"I was warned you would be stubborn." More crystal growths appeared on his arms and legs, all ready to fire with no more than a single thought. That was okay; Morgana had a few tricks of her own. There was a reason she'd rated the same level of security as Fornax and Doctor Mechanial when the capes had finally managed to bring her in.

"Whoever warned you was right. And before you die, I'm going to rip their name out of your shiny mouth, one shard at a time." With a last breath for strength, Morgana pushed off from the oven with all her might. Erinite, clearly waiting for just such an action, fired a barrage of projectiles directly at her, a slew of miniature javelins coming to shred her flesh.

\* \* \*

Wade was waiting in his office as Balaam strode through the door, staff in hand. That was to be expected; Balaam had specifically booked this time for a meeting several days prior. The very bureaucracy that hung heavily on the guild's neck was the smokescreen he'd used to conceal the true purpose for his visit. It seemed a fitting touch for such an occasion.

“Afternoon,” Wade said. He was dressed in slacks and a button-down, no doubt having come in from the Indigo offices where he was nothing more than a simple billionaire genius inventor. Of course, going out in public meant he wasn’t clad in his Doctor Mechanical suit, rendering him functionally human, save for his astounding intellect. “Today was the budget meeting for the magical department, right?”

“Actually, I don’t think that will be necessary.” Balaam made a quick motion with his staff. The doors to Wade’s office slammed shut, a slight red glow visible on the glass panes. “In fact, I don’t think we’re ever going to have another budget meeting again. Not that there should have been any to start with.” Wade blinked at him benignly as Balaam continued. “Look at what you’ve done, Wade. You took a collection of some of the most powerful and morally flexible meta-humans on the planet, and you pulled out their fangs. With the power in this guild, we could have taken over the world.”

“And then what?” Wade leaned back in his expensive, contoured leather chair. “What happens after we take over the world? Then we have to run it. Chaos breeds rebellion, and you certainly wouldn’t want to lose your place at the top of the order. So then we’d have to split into cabinets, divide up duties, and yes, have lots of meetings about things like budgets. You think this guild is bad? Five weeks of ruling the world and you’d be begging for me to build a time machine to put everything back in proper order.”

“I can’t imagine that happening.” Balaam slowly crossed the room, wary of any traps or defenses Wade might have. He’d layered himself in enough spells and wards to protect against everything short of a nuclear strike, but those who underestimated the mind of Wade Wyatt rarely lived to tell about it.

“I can, but I don’t have to,” Wade replied. “Back when I went looking for Morgana during a reality rip debacle, I crossed quite a few interesting dimensions. Or did you think my decision to go legit was merely a softening of my heart?”

“Never gave it much thought. I just know you went weak. Do you know how happy I was when I learned that not only were the legends of my

youth out of prison, but they'd formed a group of powerful villains? I expected to fight alongside you and Fornax, to lay waste to the pathetic do-gooders that are the AHC, to claim our rightful place as gods and kings. Instead I got break rooms, codes, and budget meetings. You've forgotten what it is to live with the freedom of true villainy, but I'm going to remind you. I'm going to remind this whole guild."

Balaam finished crossing the room, no traps or surprises taking him off guard. There were only a few feet between him and the still-relaxed Wade. The lack of concern on the guild leader's face was off-putting, but Balaam surmised that it had to be a bluff. Balaam had him dead to rights and Wade knew it: he was just trying to pretend he still had an ace up his sleeve.

"Even if you could kill me, the rest of the council would tear you apart for this kind of treachery," Wade told him.

"They're being dealt with," Balaam said. "I had to send in some specialists for Xelas, Morgana, and Pseudonym, but Gork and Stasis are easy to contain with the right spells. You're the last member of the council that might pose a problem, which is why I decided to handle you personally."

"Balaam, you know this doesn't end well, don't you?" Wade slipped his feet from the desk and leaned forward, causing Balaam to take a half-step backward, just in case. "I won't say there's time to turn back—you've definitely made your bed and there's no skirting the repercussions—but you can still start making some smart calls. Don't drag down more of the guild with this idiotic quest. Die with at least *some* dignity."

"You know, I think the only thing in this guild that I hate more than Pseudonym's submissive, weak-willed demeanor is that ridiculous know-it-all attitude of yours. Just because you're a great inventor doesn't make you omniscient." Balaam's grip on his staff tightened, his fingers aching from the pressure. "I'm done listening to your high-and-mighty lectures. Today, your guild burns, and mine will rise from its ashes."

"I don't think you've—"

The words were cut off as Balaam whipped his staff around and stabbed the butt of it directly into Wade Wyatt's heart. A shock of copper hair became visible as Wade looked down at his chest in surprise then met Balaam's eyes. Slowly, Wade shook his head, and let out a soft whisper.

"So be it. Just remember, this is the path you chose, Balaam. There's no one else to blame but yourself." With that, Wade's head fell backward onto the chair as his whole body went limp. It should have been a moment for celebration, but something was off. Balaam yanked his staff free of Wade's chest, and immediately realized what was wrong with the picture.

There was no blood coming from the wound, and with the staff removed, the reason was evident. Instead of a red, pulpy mess of insides like Balaam had been expecting, only circuits and sparks gleamed beneath Wade's skin.

"A fake," he muttered, though he was sure his words were still being transmitted somewhere. "You crafty bastard, you sent a fake to this meeting. Did you know what was coming? No... no, I bet you do this all the time."

This was bad. Wade Wyatt was a dangerous man, and Balaam had failed to sweep him off the game board. Still, it didn't mean all was lost. He'd taken out the rest of the council, and even Doctor Mechanical wasn't unstoppable. It would mean a harder fight; that was all.

"Nice trick!" Balaam yelled to the empty room. "Congratulations, Wade, you get to live for a few more hours. I think I actually prefer it this way. Now you can watch as your guild is destroyed."

Balaam turned from the desk, parted the doors with a motion of his staff, and stormed out of the room.

## Chapter 80

In the span of an hour, it seemed like the entire world had gone mad. Hephaestus hovered over Kelsington Prep and watched as her helmet's data stream filled with reports of an attack on downtown Ridge City. First the bombs went off, then a small horde of people in costumes started swarming the capes on the streets. Next an armada of tiny drones appeared to aid the attackers. The whole place had fallen into total chaos, and apparently Apollo was about to make a speech addressing what was happening. Clearly this was associated with the attack on her and the threats toward Ivan's kids, but Hephaestus only had the capacity to handle one problem at a time.

Right now the biggest issue was how to get Ivan's kids to safety. No, that wasn't good enough. If Rust Tooth was telling the truth, then the whole building could come crashing down, killing way more people than just Rick and Beth. Hephaestus might be a thief, a guild-certified villain, and now a killer, but she wasn't so far gone into evil that the idea of letting children die sat well with her. She had to get the whole school evacuated, but how? Lighting a fire seemed risky, and while she might be able to convince the management that they were in danger, it would take time, time they might not have. If Bombastic learned that the kids were fleeing, there was a chance he'd blow the school. Whatever she did, it needed to make them move fast.

A ringing in her ear stole her attention, and when she saw the name on the incoming call, Hephaestus nearly cried with happiness. She accepted the call and all but screamed: "Beverly! What the living fuck! I was worried about you."

"You were worried about *me*? There's news footage of some crazy person in your armor flying away from a busted house and a meta-human corpse, and you were the one worried?"

Hephaestus winced at the choice of words—she really hoped Beverly was using a secure line, otherwise anyone monitoring them just

found out that Tori Rivas's phone connected to the person in a black and red meta-suit. Well, what was done was done, so she'd just have to roll with it.

"Yeah, I'm fine, there's just some shit going down with the guild right now. I don't know what, but I'm not sure how safe any of us are. Are you in the building?"

"No, I didn't want to get pinned in by the crowds and traffic, so I went to visit my family," Beverly told her. "I was almost back when everything started going nuts. I pulled over to check the news and saw your calls. What the hell is going on?"

"Someone at the guild is planning a revolution, trying to oust the current leaders. I got targeted as Pseudonym's apprentice. Thuggernaut isn't on the council, so you might be safe, but he is pretty good friends with a lot of them. I'd recommend lying low until we see what their next move is," Hephaestus told her.

"I'm not a big fan of hiding," Beverly shot back.

"Consider it strategic information gathering," Hephaestus replied. "Until we actually know who to fight, you can't very well throw punches. How far are you from Ridge City Grinders, the place where Chloe works?"

"Couple of blocks, but traffic is impossible." Over Beverly's line the sounds of shouting and people running could be made out.

"Then walk. It's a central location, so you'll be set to respond, and Chloe might need a friend with how close she is to the shitshow. Besides, if worse comes to worse, she can teleport you both to somewhere safe."

"And what will you do while I run and hide?" Beverly asked.

"I... I don't want to talk about it over the phone." Giving away her secret identity was one thing, but the wrong word in the wrong ear could turn the school below her into an inferno. "Just trust me, it's important. I'll meet up with you as soon as I—"

A loud, blaring tone filled her ear as the emergency broadcast system built into her phone let her know there was an announcement incoming. From the cursing on the other end of the line, Beverly had also



gotten an earful. Quickly looking at the net, Hephaestus saw Apollo's form fill the screen; he stood in front of a downtown building, prepared to make a live address.

“Friends, citizens, protectors of Ridge City, today is a dark time in our town's history. It has come to our attention that the attacks you've all seen this afternoon were not, as one might have hoped, individual assaults from meta-criminals. What is happening around us is far, far worse. It seems that there has been an entire group of meta-criminals lurking in the shadows for some time—some arrested and released through legal means, others who beat the system on technicalities—all of whom have gathered together and formed a guild to share power and resources. Today they made their move, striking at the city and the AHC while we were occupied by the test of our base's defense systems, when they suspected us to be at our weakest.”

Apollo's face flickered away, showing the hordes of costumed attackers, as well as the drones sweeping in and firing at random on capes and civilians alike. Now that she was taking a good look at them, the costumes didn't seem like they would be guild-issue: they were all cheap and uninspiring. And the attackers, to a one, all had the same height. Body shape varied, but as a woman in a meta-suit, Hephaestus knew all too well how easily clothing could replicate such apparent differences. Somewhere in the back of her mind, a spark of insight tickled her skull.

A moment later the scene was gone, replaced by Apollo's solemn face.

“Thankfully, we were able to apprehend several of the perpetrators. We have learned that this was only the first step in their plan. Most of their accomplices are holed up in one location, a building only a few miles from our own, one that the AHC is currently in the process of surrounding.”

Another flicker. Hephaestus's heart sank as the familiar exterior of the guild came into view. Dozens of capes were circling up around it; several who wore masks that didn't hide their entire faces looked to be out for blood. She couldn't blame them, not really. With the narrative Apollo had constructed and a sudden attack, she'd have been pissed off too.

“I would like to address any of those villains currently hiding inside this building.” Apollo’s voice washed over her while she stared at the image of the guild. “Please, surrender yourselves willingly. Do not make today any worse than it has to be. Several of your leaders have already been taken into custody. Make the smart choice and give up. Because we will be coming in and arresting everyone, and those who resist cannot have their safety guaranteed.”

With that, the feed ended. Hephaestus realized she was still on the line with Beverly when the other woman muttered, “What the hell?”

“It’s war,” Hephaestus said, the last of the pieces falling into place. “Some of the guild got tired of peace, so they decided to fake a coordinated attack on the capes. The council would have reached out to the AHC’s leaders and told them the truth, which was why Ivan and I were attacked. Probably the others have been too. Whoever is doing this is trying to destroy the peace between our guild and the capes. They want to go back to the old ways. They want to start a war.”

“I’m feeling happy to oblige.” There was a ferocity in Beverly’s voice that Hephaestus recognized as the dragon slipping through. Much as she wanted to turn her friend loose, she could still hear Ivan’s voice cautioning her about what happened when villains and capes went to war.

“No. Not yet, Beverly. Stick to the plan. Get to Chloe and wait until you have a clear enemy, or until you’re forced to act. Just because someone tried to take out the council doesn’t mean they succeeded. Let’s see how things play out for a little longer before we make a misstep.”

“I don’t like that plan,” Beverly growled. There were a few moments of silence, and when she spoke again, her voice was normal, if annoyed. “But you’re better than I am at planning, so I’m going to trust you... for now. Just don’t keep me on the sidelines for too long. And stay by your phone.”

“No choice in the matter, the thing is patched into my helmet,” Hephaestus replied. “Stay safe, and good luck out there.”

“Same to you, with whatever you’re doing.”

The line went dead, leaving Hephaestus alone with her problem of how to forcibly evacuate a school as quickly as possible. An idea sprang to mind, born thanks to Apollo, of all people. It wouldn't exactly be the most PR-friendly way to handle the situation, but that's why she was a villain instead of a cape. She got to do the things that superheroes never would. Besides, Apollo had already whipped Ridge City into terror; she might as well use it to her own ends.

"Oh, I'm not doing much," Hephaestus said to no one, decreasing her altitude as she checked her weapon systems. "Only breaking in to a school full of children and forcing them to evacuate. No big deal, just that if this goes south, Ivan's going to rip my head off, and if it goes right, then I'm probably going to be seen as a total monster."

Her boots landed softly in the grass, and she set her sights on the nearest door.

"Fuck it. Here goes nothing."

\* \* \*

"It's bullshit," Johnny Three Dicks said, looking at the news feed of capes circling the guild's exterior. "That's obviously all Endless Blitz and the drones are Torkak's handiwork. How are they going to pin the work of two assholes on our entire guild?"

All around him were murmurs of agreement. Most of the guild members who'd been on-site had all gathered up in the same place—the giant media room near the building's center. It was used for situations when the guild was gathered to collectively witness something, like massive fights between capes and other metas or the Super Bowl. Today, it showed them the events that had led up to their home being encircled, which were playing on constant loop from the various news stations.

"They know we didn't all do it, they just don't care," said Kilo Byte. "It's a setup. The whole thing is designed to incriminate us, and by the time the dust clears, no one will care that we didn't have any involvement."

"I don't get it," Meg Byte said, shaking her head next to Kilo. "Why do the capes want to take us down so bad? The peace worked for them."

“It worked for some of them, the ones in control,” Thuggernaut corrected. “But they’ve been appearing less and less in recent years. My guess is that the new ones aren’t quite as content having known criminals nearby. Since they couldn’t get enough evidence to come after us legitimately, they decided to do it this way.”

“Then why the hell hasn’t one of the council members reached out to their leaders?” Arcanicus asked. “We know they sometimes talk. It feels like one phone call could straighten this all out.”

“Too public,” Pod Person replied. “Even if they wanted to, Apollo just aired our fake laundry in front of the entire world. They couldn’t just say ‘whoops’ and fall back. Besides, I haven’t seen any of the council members in hours.”

“Apollo did say they’d been captured,” Kilo pointed out.

“I’ll believe that shit when I see the video, and maybe not even then.” Johnny scanned the crowd, noting that Tunnel Vision had stepped into the room. “Any chance we can just get out of here before they come knocking on our door?”

“We are unable to break through space,” said the female half of Tunnel Vision. “There are several dampening devices and magical wards, not unlike what we use here, that are blocking all attempts at creating portals.”

“Saw that coming,” Arcanicus muttered darkly. “This whole thing is a trap. The only way we avoid springing it is by lying down and letting them arrest us. If there’s no resistance, then we can beat the hell out of this in court. Their evidence is fake and we’ve got good lawyers. By the time this is over, we’ll be suing the AHC for slander and wrongful arrest.”

“Smart plan,” Johnny agreed. “But unfortunately, it looks like it’s not on the table.” He pointed to the screen, where more Endless Blitz duplicates appeared to be outside the guild, along with a few other actual members.

At that, Balaam’s face suddenly appeared, constant glitches giving away that he was breaking in to the feed. He gazed out at them with his red

eyes tucked away behind the red mask he hadn't actually worn in years.

"We refuse to go quietly! We will destroy the so-called superheroes even if it takes every breath in our bodies. We shall neither surrender nor quit until we are dead. Today is the uprising. Today our guild of villains will take back the world from the terror of the AHC. No quarter will be given. Come and get us if you think you can!"

"I am going to rip his tongue out through his asshole," Scryanthos said. Around her, several members of the magical division nodded their agreement. As the mutinous murmurs died away, the room's occupants took note of how few members of the guild were present. Several members could be seen on screen, attacking the capes that were gathered outside. Glyph was, mercifully, not among them. He was standing near one of the walls, trying to look as invisible as possible, with Pest Control at his side doing his best to offer comfort.

"Much as we all want to stomp Balaam's balls into pudding, right now there's a bigger issue at hand," Thuggernaut told them. "After that little speech and the attack being mounted outside, they are going to come in here ready to kill. We can still try to surrender, but I'm not sure they'll listen."

His words were met with several seconds of silence as every villain present tried to figure out what the best path forward was. No one wanted to speak; the wrong words could tip them into a bad decision, one that would cost everyone in the room their freedom, if not their lives.

Johnny Three Dicks was exempt from such concerns.

"I don't know about you lot, but I didn't get into this racket because I fancied the idea of dying on my knees. Since it seems like avoiding a fight is off the table, what's say we at least try and fight smart? They might be out for blood, but that actually gives us an advantage. The whole nation, probably the world, is watching by now. So if the capes go in for the kill but we only aim for incapacitation that might get people wondering about just who the bad guys really are. Plus, if we can hold out long enough, hopefully the higher-ups will sort this out."

"That's a pretty damn big long shot, Johnny," Arcanicus said.

“No argument here. And if anyone has a better idea, please step forward and lay it down before us. I’m offering the best I’ve got, but I’m certainly open to other options.” Johnny stood, looking around at a sea of blank faces before speaking again. “Well then, since it seems like my bad idea is the only one we’ve got, let’s snap to it. If we wait until they get inside, there won’t be cameras, and once that happens, all bets are off. At least out there, they have to act like proper capes.”

Thuggernaut shook his head as the crowd filed out of the room, walking up slowly to his best friend in the entire guild. “Only you, Johnny. Only you could make slugging it out with the capes in public seem like the logical choice.”

“We’re well past the point where logic has anything to offer. At this time, our choices are struggle or die quietly.” Johnny patted Thuggernaut on his massive bicep. “I don’t know about you, but I’ve never been quiet while doing anything. I certainly don’t plan on starting now.”

## Chapter 81

It took all of Beverly's self-control not to use her dragon powers and knock people aside as she raced to Ridge City Grinders. Smoke was billowing from a nearby explosion and hordes of civilians were racing away from the drones sweeping the air and firing off shots at random. Once, she glimpsed someone in a costume going after a cape, but they were gone before she had a chance to consider stepping in. That was probably for the best; while *she* might be anonymous, there had to be more than a few capes on the lookout for a giant dragon creature.

Finally, she made it to the coffee shop, only to find the door locked as she pressed against it. Beverly was debating whether or not to force the thing open when Chloe appeared from behind the counter. She raced forward, unlocked the door, yanked Beverly through, then slammed it shut and flicked the lock again. Before anyone could notice the two women standing behind the glass, Chloe grabbed Beverly and dragged her beneath a booth.

Chloe let out a long sigh of relief after a full minute of silence had passed. "Sorry about that. I heard news reports about shops being looted in the chaos, so I had to lock this place down. I figure as long they don't see anyone worth mugging inside, a coffee shop isn't going to be too high up on the list of potential robbery targets."

"I'm glad you stayed safe," Beverly replied. "Things are getting nuts out there. I haven't checked the news since I left my car, but I heard a few more explosions."

"They're happening all over the place," Chloe told her. "The cops keep looking for bombs, but so far there's no luck finding any. Yet things keep exploding. And now the Alliance of Heroic Champions have found some sort of secret guild in the middle of the city that they're trying to attack."

"Right, secret guild," Beverly said. She'd almost forgotten that while Chloe knew about her and Tori's powers, they'd kept her in the dark

about their association with other criminals. “Any news on that?”

“There’s a bunch of superheroes surrounding their headquarters. They gave them the chance to give up, but some villain that’s been gone for a while—Balaam, or something, the news said—appeared and said they’d all go down fighting. Only a few have come out so far, though... um, are you okay?”

Chloe’s concern came from the fact that Beverly’s hands had turned to claws, and that she was currently snapping apart the base of the table they were hiding under. At Chloe’s words, Beverly realized what she was doing and forced herself to regain control. “I’m fine, sorry. Just... just really upset about this whole situation.”

“It is nuts,” Chloe agreed. “Why the hell would someone try to take on the AHC?”

“My guess is that they wouldn’t,” Beverly said. “Things aren’t always the way they seem, you know? This is probably a game being played by someone way up the food chain.”

“I just want it to pass by quickly.” Chloe looked around the coffee shop as if she were waiting for the ceiling to come crashing down. “At least we’re nowhere near the actual fighting.”

“For now. In this sort of situation, with the capes all busy and the city in chaos, I have a feeling the streets are going to be really dangerous for a while,” Beverly said. “After all, the guild might be a concentration of meta-human criminals, but it’s not like they’re the only game in town.”

Less than ten seconds after Beverly’s warning, they heard the sound of shattering glass. It was, mercifully, not from the front door of Ridge City Grinders, but it was close. Beverly peeked out from behind the cushioned cover of the booth to see a gang of three people unloading the contents of a pawn shop across the street. Two were clearly metas from their size and inhuman features, while the third looked normal save for the odd outfit that adorned her. From the busted shop doors extending down the street, it appeared they were making their way down the road, stealing at their leisure.



And sooner or later, they were going to reach the coffee shop where she and Chloe were hiding.

\* \* \*

It was a testament to her restraint and her years of abstaining from more spectacular displays that the mug of tea in Helen's hand wasn't shattered into shards on the floor. Nevertheless, her grip was tight as she watched the chaos playing out on the news, trying desperately to call headquarters and Ivan alternately, receiving no response. She got so desperate that she even tried Vernon, only to be told that he was on his island in the middle of a very dangerous experiment and couldn't be disturbed. So she went back to calling the other two, dialing them over and over, each time failing to connect.

"Why is everyone fighting, Mommy?" Penelope looked up from her drawings to the news footage that Helen only just now realized wasn't entirely appropriate for a girl her age. She stared with wonder at the people in colorful costumes slugging it out in the streets of downtown.

"They... it's a show, honey. The superheroes are putting on a show, a play about what the fights they used to have were like." Helen watched as the peace she'd helped forge, albeit indirectly, unraveled on the screen before her. Deep down, she'd always known this day would come, hadn't she? When she first told Ivan about her unexpected, supposedly impossible, surprise and he made that impossible promise, she'd known it was all borrowed time.

"Mommy, are you okay?" Penelope was staring up at her. Helen realized that her vision was clouded by tears on the verge of spilling.

"I'm fine," Helen lied, one more falsehood to add to the pile she'd already had to tell her daughter. "But Mommy just remembered she has an errand to run. I'm going to call Miss Teresa and see if she'll come over and play with you."

It would take at least half an hour for their elderly neighbor to arrive, time in which the situation could go from perilous to near apocalyptic. But part of her was grateful for the delay. Despite her brave words to Ivan, she wasn't quite ready to give up this peaceful existence yet.

Part of her hoped that somehow, in the time they waited for the babysitter, things would change. Ivan would make them change. All this time, he'd been a guard dog in the shadows, protecting the world's peace even if no one knew it. Asking for more, even hoping for it, was selfish and Helen knew that.

But humans are selfish creatures, so she watched the screen, barely blinking, and allowed herself to hope all the same.

\* \* \*

Attacking a school was probably pretty easy for a meta-human, at least one with her armory and level of technical sophistication. What was much harder, however, was breaking in to a school, triggering the alarms, and forcing an evacuation all without getting someone hurt in the chaos. Hephaestus sure as hell didn't want the death or injury of kids on her hands, to say nothing of what the guild would do if they found out. So as she burst through the door, burning the sprinklers to set off a fire-alarm, and then trying to steer the kids to the closest exit, she made certain to keep an eye on the children streaming away from her.

"Go! Move! Haul some ass!" At this point, she'd just accepted that dialogue was not her strong point, but as long as she growled the words out, her voice changers made them sound low and menacing, which was enough to get people moving.

From behind, her display showed movement, as a gym teacher in blue shorts that uncomfortably lived up to their name tried to sneak up on her with a fire axe. Hephaestus admired his courage, if not his fashion choices, but she couldn't really afford to take a blow to the back. Whirling around, she snatched the axe from his hands just as he lifted it overhead and snapped it at the hilt.

"Are you fucking stupid?" Her voice sounded even harsher than usual. The man paled for a moment but refused to back down. "I'm not trying to hurt anyone; I'm trying to get you all out. There are bombs somewhere in here, and you all need to *move*."

"Jesus, why didn't you just tell us?" the gym teacher demanded.

“Because then you would have asked me an idiotic question like that instead of getting the fuck out of here!” Hephaestus grabbed his shoulder and shoved him toward the students that were racing out the door. Though she was doing her best to keep an eye on them as they went, she’d yet to see either Rick or Beth. That was to be expected; this was only one exit in a pretty large school.

Taking flight, careful to keep her thrusters aimed away from the students, she zipped over their heads, checking classrooms for any stragglers along the way.

There were a lot of bad things about living in a town notorious for producing capes and the resultant, though infrequent bouts, between meta-humans. However, one upside was that people took their evacuation protocol *seriously*. No stragglers lingered; no teachers had decided to ignore the alarm as though it were a mere interruption of their lessons. People were booking it out the doors, moving all the faster when they saw a black and red meta-suit flying over their heads. From the shrieks and pointing, Hephaestus had a hunch that more than a few stories would get exaggerated. If the news didn’t ultimately depict her as gobbling the heads of schoolchildren as she soared above them, she’d call it a win.

Fast as they were moving, none of them had Rick or Beth’s face, and the longer she searched, the more worried Hephaestus grew. Granted, they might have slipped by her, gotten outside through an exit she wasn’t watching. If so, then fantastic. But she didn’t trust herself to go check until she was one hundred percent certain that the building was clear. If she missed them, if they got stuck, Ivan would never forgive her. And she wasn’t sure that she would forgive herself.

Hephaestus was doubling back at the end of a hallway when she caught sight of a dark-haired boy ducking out of sight in a classroom. With no time to waste, she landed and bashed through the door, not unlike the way Rust Tooth had entered Ivan’s home. A split second later, a Bunsen burner clattered harmlessly off her helmet, followed by a beaker and a textbook. The aim was solid, though the power wasn’t near enough to break through her armor. Glancing about, Hephaestus came to a pair of rapid realizations. She was on the familiar ground of a science classroom, and the boy pelting her with objects was Rick.

“Stay back!” He chunked a set of test tubes at her, which Hephaestus nimbly sidestepped.

“Fine, just get out,” she screamed back at him. “Can you not hear the alarms, dipshit?”

That took him by surprise; evidently, he’d been anticipating an attack, not angry advice. The chemistry book he gripped remained in his hand rather than soaring through the air like the many projectiles before. He blinked rapidly as he reevaluated the situation, showing a level of calm that Hephaestus was surprisingly impressed by. Not many people would have the presence of mind to take in changes on the fly like that; instead, they’d stick to panic. But he was Ivan’s son, after all.

“Aren’t you here to hurt us?” Rick demanded.

“No, I’m trying to get you all out before the bastard with the bombs lights this place up.” Hephaestus paused, really considering his words, and realized what she’d missed in the first scan of the room. “What do you mean, ‘us’?”

A groan from behind a table answered Hephaestus’s question before Rick could. She dashed over to confirm her suspicions. He moved right along with her, putting himself between her and the curled up form of Beth, who was lying on the ground. She didn’t seem to be injured, at least by the cursory analysis Hephaestus could perform, but that was not the biggest issue at hand.

Silver spikes were pulsing out of Beth’s skin, appearing and vanishing, leaving no trace or scar when they slipped out of sight. Some were straight and sharp, others curved and serrated, but all seemed deadly and malleable, like they were formed from quicksilver.

“How long?” Hephaestus looked from Beth to Rick and grabbed the young man by the collar of his shirt. “How long has your sister been a meta-human?”

“I don’t know!” Rick tried to slap her hand away, but unlike Beth, he was mundane and therefore lacked the strength to move one as strong as

Hephaestus. “The alarms went off, I ran to find her, and I saw her stumbling in here. By the time I got in, she was like this.”

“I got scared,” Beth murmured from her prone position on the floor. “It... they come when I’m scared.”

“So this has happened before.” Hephaestus let Rick down and kneeled over Beth. The blades lengthened and pointed toward her, so she scooted a few inches back. “Listen, I’m here to help you. I need to get you both out of here.”

“Fuck that. We’re not going anywhere with some crazy meta.” Rick planted himself between her and Beth with what little space there was. The kid might not be making the smartest tactical decisions, but he was doing his best to shield his little sister. That part Hephaestus sort of admired. But they didn’t have time for it. She needed them out, right now. Who knew when the bombs could go?

It seemed like there was only one option; she just hoped Ivan could think of a good lie to explain how he’d known her. Hephaestus reached up and grabbed the latches on each side of her helmet. She was just about to press them in when a small hand landed on her arm, tugging it away from the helmet.

“We’ll go,” Beth said, pulling herself up using Hephaestus’s body for leverage. “If you say we need to go, then we will.”

“We don’t know who this guy is,” Rick pointed out.

“But he could have attacked us, or grabbed us, and he didn’t,” Beth replied. “I lost my secret today, Rick. I can’t take away someone else’s.” As she spoke, the blades seemed to be getting shorter, springing out from her body less frequently. No doubt they reacted to her state of mind, which meant she was in for a long road ahead to get proper control, but at least she had the right father to get her the help she would need.

“Appreciate the trust. I’m harder to cut, so I’ll help carry you. Rick, you come with us and lead the way—”

Hephaestus’s orders were cut off by the deafening sound of an explosion. The roof tumbled downward as the sound of more explosions

filled the air.

Hephaestus, and Ivan's kids, had run out of time.

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## Chapter 82

“Do the shackles feel familiar? I specially brought in your old set from Rookstone. I’m aware that they aren’t quite as effective without that cell and its specialty wards, but I think they’re really more symbolic in the first place.”

Ivan looked up at the new voice in the room. He knew the man lit by a golden glow; the curly hair and constant smile were unmistakable, even if two of his known flunkies hadn’t kidnapped Ivan from his office and dragged him to the empty floor of another building. The room’s only accessories were the metal chair he was sitting in, the large shackles binding his forearms, and of course, the five circles of runes between him and his jailers. Blunderbuss and Lady Shade both stood a bit straighter as the man walked in, like they’d been called to attention.

“Apollo, right? I’ve seen you on the news a few times.” Ivan wasn’t sure why he bothered being surly, save that it was the lone avenue of protest he still possessed.

“Come now, you’ve seen me far more than a few,” Apollo replied. “I’m all over the place. I’m basically the new Lodestar.”

Ivan’s eyes flickered, switching to the red runes for a half second. He met Apollo’s cheer with a grim smile of his own. “Kid, you might be a lot of things, but the new Lodestar isn’t among them. You aren’t worth the shit on the bottom of Lodestar’s shoes. Even if you had her power—and you don’t—she would never stoop so low as to hold someone’s children hostage.”

“Me, hold hostages? I’m appalled by the idea.” Apollo walked forward, crossing the warded circles without concern, despite the worry on Lady Shade’s face. He came within spitting distance of Ivan, and then hunkered down so the two were eye-to-eye.

“I didn’t have to take hostages, Fornax. There was already someone out there more than happy to do it for me. That little guild of yours is

wrong; it goes against the ideas of decency and law that this country was founded upon. Every time I had to go to a crime scene where we knew you were the perpetrators but lacked the evidence to prove it, I hated you a little more. But it never occurred to me that I wasn't the only one who saw the way you'd violated the natural order. Imagine my shock when I finally caught one of you in the act, only to find we were of a like mind."

Apollo reached into his costume and pulled out a glowing red stone. He set it gently on the floor, and suddenly an illusion manifested in the air above it. Balaam's smug satisfaction at seeing Ivan in shackles could be felt radiating off him even without his physical presence. The traitor was still adorned in his villain costume, complete with the mask that matched the blood-red of his irises.

"My, how many times have I dreamed about this moment, seeing you broken and kenneled like the mutt you are," Balaam said.

"You see, Fornax—or we can call you Ivan if you prefer—Balaam is the one who took your children hostage. We merely acted as middle men." Apollo walked around the chair slowly, letting his words echo through the empty room. "I'll admit, it isn't the most heroic act I've undertaken, but it was a necessary tactic to keep you under control. The rest of your council is being captured, or killed if they resist, but you were too dangerous. Anyone who can fight on the same level as Lodestar is too big a risk to tangle with."

Apollo finished his rotation and looked into Ivan's eyes once more. "Your guild is done, Ivan Gerhardt. We will level it to the foundation and arrest you all for the myriad of crimes you've managed to get away with until today. Right now, the AHC is raiding your headquarters; with none of the council to help, I imagine the lack of power and leadership will make for a quick victory. But we know there are security measures in place designed to destroy any evidence that might make our court cases simpler. You can still save yourself, Ivan. Play ball, tell us how to get what we need, and perhaps you can get out with a reduced sentence."

"And if I don't, you kill my kids." Ivan spat, glaring at Apollo.

Despite the fact that Ivan was seated, Apollo took a slight step back. "How about a little credit here; I'm not a monster," he replied. "I won't play



that card to make you talk. If you want to stay silent, you can go down with the rest of your guild.”

“Even Balaam?” Ivan asked.

“Oh, we’re most certainly enemies,” Balaam replied, still shimmering in and out of focus above the stone. “But I at least respect that relationship. Not all the guild members were in the base, you know. Lots of us were scattered about, living our own lives. When this is done, I’ll gather them up, and we can finally restart the organization the way it should have been. No more hiding, no more slinking about. We meet the capes head on, a contest of power, and when we wipe them from the Earth, our victory will be all the sweeter.”

“Balaam and I both want this world the way it’s supposed to be: heroes acting like heroes, villains acting like villains,” Apollo said. “This red tape bullshit ends today. I’m willing to give you a little leeway here, Ivan. I know you tried to go straight. Just help us out, and perhaps we can make that dream come true.”

Ivan leaned his head back, tilting his eyes away from Balaam and Apollo, gazing up at the gray ceiling. “You are all so impossibly stupid, I don’t even know where to start. Trying to shatter peace, even if it’s not one you agree with, is the work of the mad and the wicked, so I understand why Balaam would do it. But you, Apollo, I’d thought maybe you were a bit smarter. Then again, you both also made some serious other miscalculations.”

He leaned forward, and this time, Apollo’s step backward was more of a jump. Ivan’s eyes blazed in a way that had nothing to do with his power, rage and disdain burning inside them. “Do you really think the council will die that easily? Do you really think the guild is made up of weaklings to be easily captured or killed? There’s a reason your betters agreed to this peace, Apollo, and it wasn’t just for convenience. All of us are smart, strong, and determined enough to have won our freedom or caught the eye of more experienced villains. None of us, not one, is weak and disposable. None of us got our job because we looked good on camera or had a knack for dealing with the press. If you can’t say the same, then I hope you prepared for this mission by digging a mass grave, because even

if you get your wish—*especially* if you get your wish—you’re going to need it.”

Apollo was rendered speechless by the tirade, but Balaam, unfortunately, was not. “You know, Ivan, I’ve always hated that stubborn streak of yours. Deep down, that’s half of why I agreed to this plan. It allowed me to finally see you broken and humbled. I’d thought being helpless, your children under threat, your body shackled by pathetic pissants you could easily rip through, that would be enough to bring you there. But it seems I miscalculated. An error I will now rectify.” The tip of his staff glowed and the sorcerer leaned forward, whispering into it. “Bombastic, liquidate our holdings.”

Balaam vanished. In his place was a new illusion, one of Kelsington Prep from above. Before anyone could speak, a series of explosions tore through it, collapsing the structure inward and turning what remained into a smoking inferno. Then it was gone and Balaam was back, a wide smile plastered across his face.

“Balaam, what the *fuck!*” Apollo reached forward to grab Balaam’s neck and only stopped himself after his hands were halfway through the hologram. “That was a bluff! There were never supposed to be any actual bombs at the school. Those were *kids*, you son of a bitch.”

“Correction: those were Ivan’s kids, along with a bit of collateral damage,” Balaam replied, tilting his staff toward the shackled man. Ivan’s eyes had closed and his hands were clenched so tightly that the knuckles were turning white. “And as much as I loathe Ivan, I’m something of a Fornax fan-boy. With no more family to weigh him down, I’m curious to see if the ancient terror makes a reappearance.”

“That’s insane. You just blew up a school to antagonize him? I thought you wanted him out of the way!” Apollo was on the verge of tears, the image of the falling school seared into his mind. That wasn’t how this was supposed to go; they’d mapped everything out so carefully, and the mass murder of children was never a part of it.

“I wanted *Ivan* out of the way. Fornax is another matter entirely. He’ll be an excellent distraction while my people lead the counterattack on your superheroes,” Balaam replied.

“Attack... no, you’re supposed to lie low, let us pick off the ones at the base,” Apollo said.

“Honestly, I can’t believe you weren’t expecting a betrayal.” Balaam twirled his staff once and the gem began to flicker. “The older capes never would have fallen for something like this. Oh, and Ivan was right: I might have misled you on how tough of a fight you’ll be facing at the guild headquarters. Some will certainly survive, at least until reinforcements arrive. *You* might be able to handle us, but something tells me you’ll be... occupied.”

With that, the stone flickered out, leaving Apollo alone inside the warded circles with the man in the chair who’d failed to say a word since a school came down on top of his children. Apollo began backing away quickly, getting past the safety of the first few circles before he even tried to speak.

“Ivan, that wasn’t us. That was Balaam. And all we saw was the building go down. Your kids might be okay.”

“Balaam is too thorough. The bomb was too big. They’re dead. You trusted that madman, and now my children are dead.” Ivan barely stirred, but his arms surged, gripping each shackle and tearing through it like they were made of wet paper. Dark, pulsing lines of energy were running across his skin, and as he stood up, the chair beneath him exploded into chunks. Slowly, he turned to Apollo and opened his eyes. They were completely black, save for the red runes that burned so brightly it was like staring into the very fires of hell.

“Did you really want to see Fornax that badly?” His voice was different, higher and inhuman, the way Apollo imagined a cobra would sound like if it could talk. Ivan took a single step forward and the first circle of wards exploded into red flames, quickly turning to nothing more than scorch marks.

“Are those things going to hold him?” Blunderbuss yelled, whipping his gun around.

“We had the best magic users we could trust make them,” Lady Shade replied. “Each one could hold the magical equivalent of a charging

rhino.”

Another step. The second circle exploded and turned to ash. Ivan shook his head and cast Lady Shade a single glance that filled her with so much terror she was afraid to even shake. “Chaos magic is much harder to bind.”

Third step. This circle burned for a bit longer.

“Ivan, I know you’re mad, but this is what Balaam wants. Help us go get him. We all want revenge, so let’s make it happen together.” Apollo flexed his arms even as he spoke of peace, trying to draw up as much power as possible. He’d seen the tapes of Fornax just like almost everyone else, and deep down, he’d always wondered if he could take the legendary villain, one on one. It wasn’t something he necessarily wanted to test at this precise moment, but it seemed like Ivan would be the one making that choice.

“Balaam is going to die.” The fourth circle burned away. “Everyone is going to die. All of his, all of yours. Everyone.”

The fifth circle started to burn, and Ivan vanished.

Apollo swept the room, looking for him, only to find that he’d reappeared directly behind Blunderbuss. Ivan put each of his hands on either side of the bearded superhero’s head, and from the look on Blunderbuss’s face, it was far from comfortable.

“They really wanted you, Fornax. They wanted you so badly they killed Rick and Beth to make you come out.” Ivan was smiling now, a madman’s grin as he pushed harder on Blunderbuss’s skull. “If they want you that bad, I guess you have to come out. Just do one thing for me, since they went to all that trouble.”

Apollo tried to start forward, finally reacting, but he was too late. One quick pump of pressure and blood and brain matter were raining out from the stump where Blunderbuss’s head had sat. Most of it got on Ivan, who seemed unbothered. No, he was relishing it, smearing the blood and flecks of skull across his face until it dripped down his neck and ears.

He turned to Apollo, an insane smile carved into his blood-soaked face, and whispered in a voice that etched itself into the darkest parts of Apollo's soul.

*“Kill them all.”*

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## Chapter 83

Johnny Three Dicks ran, ducking under a mighty swing by a cape decked out in green tights, coming up behind a female one who was facing the other way. She spun around, eyes literally glowing, and let loose a blast of energy that caught him just above the neck, neatly separating his head from his torso and sending the former rolling across the ground.

As he was about to die, the world before his eyes flashed in a blue light, and then...

Johnny Three Dicks ran, ducking under a mighty swing by a cape decked out in green tights, coming up behind a female one who was facing the other way. She spun around, eyes literally glowing, and let loose a blast of energy... which sailed cleanly over Johnny's head as he ducked the attack and kicked her squarely in the stomach. She stumbled back but quickly recovered, putting out both hands and blasting Johnny into a bloody streak on the street.

Another flash of blue light and...

Johnny Three Dicks ran, ducking under a mighty swing by a cape decked out in green tights, coming up behind a female one who was facing the other way. She spun around, eyes literally glowing, and let loose a blast of energy, which sailed cleanly over Johnny's head as he ducked the attack and kicked her squarely in the stomach. As she stumbled back, he followed, his own eyes and hands beginning to glow exactly like hers had.

He struck her with both attacks at once, and while it wasn't enough to kill her, she did collapse to the ground, small tendrils of smoke wisping off the top of her forehead.

"And that's why they call me Johnny Three Dicks, doll. No matter which way you try to come, you're still fucked."

A fresh explosion interrupted his gloating, one much louder than any of the others they'd heard so far. Johnny scanned the crowd to see what had caused it. The guild members had poured into the street and were

currently holding their own against the flood of capes trying to bring them down. It was a stalling tactic, nothing more, and everyone knew it. Even as Thuggernaut and Arcanicus knocked out their opponents, more capes stepped up to take their place. The superheroes simply outnumbered them by too wide of a margin. Add in that all of the council was missing and that they were trying to avoid killing, and the fight was simply unwinnable. All they were doing was stalling for time, hoping that something in the situation would eventually change.

That change burst into being. It flickered between buildings as it chased the golden light of Apollo, who was fleeing so quickly that there was an afterglow trailing him. Johnny was at just the right angle to see the charred top floor of a nearby office building. It looked like it had been smote by an angry god more than bombed, and as the blood-soaked horror chasing Apollo slipped into view, Johnny realized that that was exactly what had happened.

Pseudonym... no, *Fornax* was on Apollo's heels, leaping off the buildings and teleporting to close the distance. He looked like Death made mortal, grin so wide it may as well have been that of a fleshless skull. Each time he got near the glowing cape, he would claw and swing at Apollo wildly, attacking more like an animal than a man. Even so, those wild blows were enough to knock Apollo off course, and left a trail of craters and broken windows in the nearby buildings.

Johnny had been hoping for a change, but this was not what he had in mind. Moving as quickly as he dared, he ran over to Thuggernaut and climbed on top of the giant meta's shoulders. Hoping dearly that no one would take a potshot at him—more out of a concern for time than safety—he pressed his hands to his mouth and yelled as loudly as possible.

“EVERYONE STOP!”

To his shock, as much as the surprise of everyone around, it worked. No one had ever tried to call a time-out in a meta-human brawl before, but the strangeness of it was so potent that people actually paid attention. It certainly helped that Fornax and Apollo tearing through the sky had already caused a few of them to split their focus. With no time to dawdle, Johnny capitalized on the moment of hesitation.

“We need to get the hell out of here right now. All of us. Cape, guild, civilian, we need to clear this town like it’s burning, because in about five minutes, it will be.”

“It’s a trick. They’re trying to escape,” yelled a cape from the crowd, one Johnny recognized as Battle Cry.

“No, he’s trying to save us all.” From nearby, a shadow bubbled up from the ground, shifting to reveal the familiar form of Lady Shade. She was clutching her arm in pain and limping with every movement. “Fornax has gone insane. He... he believes the AHC killed his children. When the fight with Apollo is done, he’s going to come for the rest of us, and I’m not sure Fornax will stop there. We need another member of the Champions’ Congress to help or all is lost.”

“Where’s Quorum?” Baron Peppermint hollered. He and Pest Control’s minions were inches away from a brawl, but both armies were paused, waiting on orders from their masters.

“Locked away inside a cell in the AHC, which is sealed inside the dome for at least another hour,” Lady Shade told them. There were more than a few murmurs at such information, many of the capes glaring at Lady Shade with new distrust. “The system is automated because we were running tests, and the sole people who could deactivate it are the members of the Congress, only one of which is inside.”

“Can Apollo last a full hour?” This question came from Glyph, whose wand was halfway through etching a rune of explosive force into the street.

“No.” Thuggernaut shook his head under Johnny, the deep rumble of his voice carrying through the street. “Not when Fornax is like this, and not alone. What about Lodestar or Professor Quantum?”

Many of the older capes shuffled uncomfortably, until Combust stepped forward. “We haven’t seen either of them in years. Lodestar is apparently off on some secret mission, and Professor Quantum doesn’t usually leave his island. The only ones that know how to get in contact with them are Quorum and Apollo.”



“Then it looks like we have to find a way to break in to AHC headquarters,” Johnny declared.

“Quite an interesting theory, but I wonder how you’ll accomplish such a task.” The disembodied voice of Balaam hung over them until a giant pillar of flame appeared down the street seconds later. Other pillars could be seen popping up throughout the city—at least five that Johnny could see. When the nearest one vanished, Balaam appeared with at least sixty other people clustered behind him. A few were recognizable members of the guild, Endless Blitz and Torkak among them, but the rest were total strangers.

“Guild, meet the meta-human crooks that you’ve been lording over for the past several years. Capes, meet the meta-criminals you’ve been trying to bust and bring to justice. Is it any wonder that when I approached them about wiping you both out, they jumped at the opportunity? So go ahead and free Quorum from the AHC, if you can. Meanwhile, my *new* guild will be doing its best to kill you all, along with terrorizing civilians and destroying whatever they feel like.” Balaam leaned his staff forward and called to the gang behind him.

“Bring forth chaos, and kill to your hearts’ content!”

And with those words, war poured into the streets of Ridge City.

\* \* \*

Fornax’s rage was, somewhat ironically, the only thing keeping Apollo alive. The villain was more monster than man at this point, every blow so powerful it made Apollo feel like little more than a mere human. But he was so angry and wild that his attacks mirrored his feelings, which made them just a bit easier to dodge. Apollo had tried blocking one blow early on and now had a fractured left forearm to show for it. It had been so long since *anything* hurt him, yet a mere glancing punch had been enough to crack his bones. Thankfully he healed quickly, and within five minutes or so, his arm would be back to normal. Unfortunately, he wasn’t sure he would survive that long.

Apollo had made a lot of miscalculations—that was all too evident as he spiraled through the sky, skirting to the side to avoid yet another

attack by the almost-untrackable Fornax. Trusting Balaam had been foolish; if the burned school didn't tell him that, then the pillars of fire and sudden flood of criminals certainly did. And he'd certainly misgauged how powerful Fornax was. Had Lodestar really managed to fight this beast? No, to *defeat* him? Apollo's respect for the absentee superhero ticked up a few notches.

He shot through the air, taking note of the metas rioting in the streets. Had... had he really caused this? All because he couldn't stand one small group of criminals playing the system. At the time, it had seemed so noble as he worked tirelessly to take them down. But now, with both a literal and metaphorical bird's eye view, Apollo could see that it had been his own pride driving him, not a sense of justice. Even if the guild's existence had been wrong, it was certainly much better than the chaos he'd unleashed. Neither was right, but the guild was more right than this.

Apollo's distraction came with a toll. Fornax suddenly appeared above him, landing a blow directly into Apollo's shoulder and sending him to the ground like a falling star. The superhero slammed into the earth with enough force to leave a crater and send everyone nearby tumbling. Before he could get up, Fornax was there, looming over him with that damned smile, still soaked in Blunderbuss's blood.

*"Is that all your little shard of divinity is good for?"* That voice, it didn't belong to Ivan, Apollo was sure of it. Whatever he was fighting, there was no trace of the man they'd captured anymore. It was more like something that was wearing Ivan like a puppet. But no one had ever mentioned a split personality or other entity. Had it never come out before? Was this the real Fornax, seeing the light of day for the first time?

A powerful hand pulled Apollo up from the ground, gripping his broken shoulder so tightly that he knew escape was impossible. *"The others might go quickly, but you're going to suffer for your sins."*

Mustering all the power he could, Apollo focused his energy into his eyes, met Fornax's, and let out a blast powerful enough to carve through an entire block of steel. It hit dead on, right in the rune-covered targets that were Fornax's eyes. A sharp cry rang out, and Apollo felt the merciful release of freedom as Fornax's grip loosened for an instant. That instant was

all he needed. He raced into the sky once more, leaving the villain rubbing at his eyes.

Apollo was fifty feet into the sky when he heard the howl, an unholy torrent of sound rising up from Fornax's gullet. All around him, glass shattered, concrete cracked, and plants wilted. Those red-runed eyes were locked on Apollo. If anything, Fornax was angrier now than before.

Having learned his lesson, Apollo didn't stick around for the show. He raced across the sky, trying to get as much distance as possible.

It might have been the cowardly action, and it certainly felt that way as Apollo tried to lead the monster out of downtown, but there wasn't any other choice. He couldn't beat Fornax alone, and as soon as Apollo died, all of Fornax's wrath would be turned on the other superheroes. Every minute he stayed alive bought them time to prepare a counterattack.

Apollo knew he was dead no matter what happened. He'd made a terrible mistake and would pay the price for it. The least he could do was try and die like the superhero he'd always aspired to be. If he could buy the others even a slightly better chance of survival, he'd run to the ends of the Earth, no matter how cowardly it made him feel.

\* \* \*

The crowd was now nearing the remains of the school when the energy beam tore out from the far side. Screams filled the air as the people ran, which meant only the bravest of the bunch got to see the figure in black-and-red armor making its way out of the newly-carved hole, a student slung over each arm. Hephaestus took careful steps forward, making sure not to pointlessly jostle Rick or Beth. They'd both gotten knocked around quite a bit in the collapse, but neither seemed to have any major injuries that she could discern.

It was Beth's power that had saved them, those strange silver blades whipping out of her at impossible speeds, neatly slicing through every large piece of debris that had come down toward them. The small bits had still gotten through, and despite Hephaestus's best efforts to shield the kids, they'd both been pelted with more than their fair share of rubble. Both were

conscious, though, and no bones seemed broken, even if they were sore all over.

She'd barely made it ten steps out of the building before several police officers ran up to her. Probably came when she set off the fire alarm. Damn, this place really did have good security. If she ever had kids, she'd have to look into sending them here. Assuming it was rebuilt in time.

"Release the hostages and put your hands up." This came from a cop with a bushy mustache and a hand resting a little too firmly on his firearm. Thankfully, before she could curse him out, Rick took charge.

"We're not hostages. He saved us from the collapse," he told them. Hephaestus let him and Beth go, careful to make sure they were steady on their feet. "He's a hero."

"Let's not go quite that far," Hephaestus protested. "But, officer, these two need immediate medical treatment. Did an EMT and ambulance come too?"

The officer nodded, not drawing his weapon but not releasing it either. "We've got several. They're already digging for any who might still be stuck inside. Not everyone is accounted for."

Hephaestus felt the bottom of her stomach fall out. She hadn't been thorough enough. She'd missed someone. Even if Rick and Beth were safe, that was a heavy weight to bear. With a lot of effort, she pushed the overwhelming sense of guilt to the back of her mind. There would time to deal with it later; right now, someone was plotting against her guild. She needed to see what had happened while she was buried.

"Please get these two medical attention right away," Hephaestus ordered while she refreshed the news feed inside her helmet. "Top of the line, bill it to Indigo Technologies. They can call for confirmation if need be." She had no idea if Wade's company had any provisions set aside to take care of Ivan's kids, but it seemed like a safe bet. And if not, a call would certainly set things straight.

The news feed finally refreshed, and Hephaestus was very glad she'd already barked out the orders. If she'd tried to talk right then, the

words might have choked in her throat.

All of the coverage was either about the blood-soaked man chasing and gaining on Apollo or the sudden war of meta-humans that had broken out in the streets. The former was Ivan, but what on earth... the explosion. He knew. He'd seen it. He must think Rick and Beth had been killed.

Moments later, the news replayed Lady Shade's confession for the hundredth time in only so few minutes, confirming Hephaestus's suspicions. She'd have shivered if she weren't largely composed of fire within the suit. If Ivan believed his children were dead, then he'd gone completely off the deep end. The truth might be able to calm him down, but only if he would listen and believe it.

Hephaestus tried to take a step away so she could launch off again, but Beth's hand held her in place.

"Thank you for saving us."

"You did most of the work," Hephaestus told her. "That's some power you've got. Maybe one day, you'll get to tell me how it happened. But for right now, I have to go help other people."

Beth didn't respond verbally. She just hugged Hephaestus tightly, the silver blades shrinking back so as not to pierce the suit. She released the embrace and walked over to join her brother, who was standing by the ambulance that had pulled up.

The officers began to approach, which Hephaestus took as her cue to leave. She blasted off into the sky, zipping out of sight before they could even think to take a shot at her, and made a beeline for downtown Ridge City. Someone had to talk Ivan down, and it was too risky to try and bring his kids into that fray. She just had to hope that the bond between teacher and apprentice was enough to pry open his ears.

Otherwise, Hephaestus was flying at breakneck speed to her own funeral.

## Chapter 84

“I have to stop them.” Beverly’s eyes were already beginning to glow green as she peered around the booth to spy on the robbers across the street.

“Why? We’re just a coffee shop. They might not want to rob us in the first place,” Chloe pointed out. “And even if they do, I can jump us somewhere safe.”

“No, you don’t get it,” Beverly said, rising slowly from their hidden position. “I’m not saying I need to do it to protect us, I’m saying I *have* to stop them. I might hate the AHC with a fiery passion, I might be a secret meta and have bent my fair share of the law myself, and it might be the stupidest thing I can do right now, but I still have to do it. This is my town; I’m not letting these people turn it to shit.” She paused, looking at Chloe carefully. If there was ever a time for honesty, at least with someone outside the guild, then it was before she went to take on three unknown metas and potentially died.

“And I have to do it because I’m a member of that guild they’re talking about,” Beverly admitted. “We’re not doing what they claim, though, at least not all of us. Mostly we commit crimes that don’t hurt anyone, and we put down a lot of the criminals that *do* hurt people. These little punks are intruding on my guild’s turf just because we’re busy, and as a point of pride, that pisses me right the hell off. So I’m going to show them the error of their ways.”

“You’re... you’re part of that guild?” Chloe glanced at the television screen then pulled herself up from under the booth. “**Liar, liar, pants on fire.** Now, was what you just said true? Are you really not the ones doing all of this?”

“Not that I know of. The guild we were shown, the code we were taught, it would never allow for any of this. Whoever is pulling it might be members, but they don’t represent the guild that I joined.” Beverly glanced down at her pants, happy to see they were still intact.

“Then I’m going with you,” Chloe declared. “They’ll have to deal with the power of... maybe I’ll go by Cliché.”

“Probably want to work on that name. And the offer is sweet, but you’re not a fighter,” Beverly countered.

“No, I’m not. But I am a friend, and you never know when my power will come in handy. Now, do you want to debate, or do you want to take them by surprise?” Chloe walked over and unlocked the coffee shop door, pushing it open as quietly as possible.

Much as Beverly didn’t like it, Chloe was an adult who could make her own decisions. And honestly, having a little backup was a comforting thought, even if said backup was just a meta with a power that hinged on wordplay. Beverly followed her and stepped through the open door, fully shifting into her green dragon-form. She surveyed her enemies. Bahamut had arrived, and it was time to do some damage.

The first looked like a wolfman from a bad 1950’s television show. Shaggy brown fur hung off him, almost (but not quite) covering the thick muscles knotted under his skin. The second had a mostly human appearance, if one discounted the bug-like eyes and giant horn on his face. He also had to be pushing three hundred pounds, almost none of which was fat. They seemed to be doing most of the heavy lifting while the third supervised.

She was somehow the oddest of the bunch, despite looking totally human. The woman appeared to be in her twenties, with pale skin and lips that were too red. Smudges of makeup gave away that the complexion was artificial, however. Her outfit was what was most striking—a giant pink-and-black frilly dress like one might see at the turn of the century with a skirt that stuck out three feet in all directions, matching leggings, platform shoes, and a parasol that was clutched carefully in her dainty hands.

Meta-human 101 dictated that the woman would actually be the strongest of the bunch, both given their group dynamic and the fact that her powers weren’t obvious. That said, Bahamut wasn’t sure she could handle all three at once. If the big guys were all physical, she could knock them out and then focus on the weirdly dressed lady. For a moment, she considered yelling a warning to the group of robbers, but then remembered that even if

she was temporarily playing the part, Bahamut wasn't a cape. She didn't need to bother with that kind of nicety.

Her charge was thunderous and quickly noticed by the group, although not quick enough to matter. Bahamut slammed a shoulder into the wolfman, sending him flying through the remains of the broken glass window, through the store, and into the back wall, where he crashed heavily and slid to the floor. Bug-eyes reacted quickly, reaching for her with hands too big for his body. She responded by punching him right in the gut, sending him stumbling backward but not taking him off his feet.

A soft giggle from behind her was all the warning Bahamut got before a platform shoe whizzed toward her scaly green temple. She ducked the attack, twisting around to counter, only to have her claws—claws that could gouge through stone—bounce harmlessly off the surface of the pink-and-black parasol. Bahamut was so shocked that she didn't notice the second kick toward her head; this time it connected. The blow shouldn't have even registered, but suddenly Bahamut was airborne, tumbling until she crashed into the brick exterior of a nearby building. Pulling herself up took effort. Her bell had been rung so hard that her vision was blurry.

“Oh my, just another brute after all.” The woman in the dress giggled, twirling her parasol through the air in an artful pattern. “And here I thought you might be a little more fun than my underlings. Someone with the power of dragons seems so unique and mystical. Pity you're no better than a pair of barely passable mutagen experiments.”

“And what does that make you?” Bahamut spat, doing her best to buy time so her body could recover. Unfortunately, that tactic cut both ways. The wolfman made his way out from inside the busted store and the weird bug-eyed guy seemed to shake off her attack.

“Me? I'm what true success looks like. I'm the pinnacle of what metas can, and should, be! A perfect—AAAAA!” Her lilting taunts turned into a high-pitched scream as the leggings beneath her skirt suddenly burst into cascading blue flames. She smacked at them, so desperate that she dropped her parasol and beat at her burning legs with both hands.

“What... ‘liar, liar, pants on fire.’ Guess arrogant false claims count too,” Bahamut chuckled. The wolfman and bug-eyed horn guy looked



distressed at their leader's sudden terror. That was all the invitation she needed to pounce. As she tore through the street on a crash course for the two dumbstruck hulks, she saw Chloe's familiar pixie cut darting forward toward the woman with the burning legs. Part of her wanted to yell at the barista to steer clear, but the truth was she needed the help.

And besides, that parasol lady had kicked Bahamut around like a toy, yet Chloe had managed to stop her cold. Maybe she could handle the weird little thief better. But just in case, Bahamut decided to make short work of the other crooks.

If Chloe needed help, Bahamut would be there.

\* \* \*

A sledgehammer bounced off Cyber Geek's armor, sending him sprawling to the ground and knocking a huge percentage off his shields. He spun around to find a woman clad in a spiked leather jacket. She had glowing yellow eyes, and a matching light flickered across the hammer. Augmentation, probably, which was why a mundane object had managed to pack such a wallop.

Cyber Geek rolled to the side, just missing her follow-up strike that shattered the concrete below. Leaping to his feet, Cyber Geek aimed his gun, pausing only to do a quick check of his surroundings.

Everything had turned into chaos within seconds, the gangs that Balaam had brought swarming over cape and villain alike. Medley was fending them off three at a time, and Cold Shoulder had formed her ice construct to try and cover him. Hat Trick, while not great in combat, was proving herself invaluable in evacuating citizens. She could throw an endless rope of rainbow scarves from either sleeve and was using it to swing around the battlefield, snaring civilians out of precarious situations and throwing them toward the fringes of the fight. More than a few people were going to have bruises and scrapes, but it was a lot better than them seeing the inside of a coffin.

Unfortunately, his whole team being busy meant there was no one to back him up as the sledgehammer lady raced in, swinging wildly and moving too quickly for Cyber Geek to line up a shot. He backpedaled,

wishing that the armor didn't cover his computer so he could yank out a melee weapon, trying to think of a countermeasure. Working as a team had gotten him too accustomed to having Medley to cover the close-range fighting, and now he was paying the price for his lack of strategy.

Backpedaling without looking was a dangerous method, and soon Cyber Geek's luck ran out. He clipped a curb and went sprawling onto his back. Sledgehammer lady didn't even hesitate. She sprang forward with her weapon raised overhead to deliver the coup de grace. That hammer was still overhead as a swarm of what looked like the demonic forefathers of wasps swarmed her face. The little beasts stung her across the neck as they landed. Her scream—half fury, half panic—lit through the street as she swung wildly at them, but sledgehammers weren't meant to act as bug-swatters. On the third attempt to knock the bugs away, she banged her own temple and went down hard. Cyber Geek was pretty sure she was still breathing, but he wasn't certain. For a moment, he thought he saw a flicker of light near her neck, then the bugs shifted, blocking his view, and when they cleared again, it was gone.

"Come on, get up." A hand appeared over him, and he grabbed it without thinking. To his surprise, it was not the mask of a fellow AHC member that he saw as he rose, but rather the purple and black costume of one of the guild members that had come pouring out from their base. On reflex, Cyber Geek raised his blaster, and the villain quickly put his hands in the air.

"Whoa, whoa, hang on. We just saved you."

"We?" Cyber Geek asked, quickly searching the area.

"Yeah, we." This voice came from a man in a strange white costume that totally obscured his face, as if the swarm of buzzing monster wasps circling him didn't do a good enough job of that. "I'm Pest Control, and the guy you're holding a gun on is Glyph. And yes, we're villains of the guild you showed up to bust today, but can we all agree that for the moment we have bigger concerns?"

Pest Control wasn't wrong, no matter how much the insects buzzing around him made Cyber Geek's stomach roil. Whatever the situation might have been before, the sudden flood of meta-criminals represented a threat to

both sides. Maybe the guild *had* attacked the city and the AHC—though at this point, Cyber Geek was beginning to suspect there might be more going on than he'd been told—but they definitely hadn't been as ferocious as the metas attacking now. More than once, at least before the gangs showed up, he'd seen them go for the knockout rather than the kill, a sentiment their new enemies didn't share.

Still, they were self-admitted villains, which meant he couldn't trust them.

"Maybe there are," Cyber Geek admitted. "But if I take you two down, that's one less problem to worry about."

"Sure, maybe," Pest Control said. "Or maybe we came and found you for a reason. That gun of yours is pretty powerful, you know. Everyone saw the news footage of your fight in the club. It's from *Blaster Brahs*, isn't it?"

"You play?" That really wasn't an appropriate response, but under Cyber Geek's costume, Donald's reactions were too well-ingrained and hard to shake.

"All the time. Big fan." Pest Control nodded to the blaster still aimed at Glyph. "And assuming you've leveled that bad boy up enough, there should be a function to break through energy barriers. You have to use it on the final level to infiltrate the Nega-Brah's compound."

"I... you're right." Cyber Geek felt the tumblers fall into place as he gazed at the weapon.

"We think you might be able to punch through the barrier and get Quorum." Glyph slowly lowered his hands, careful to keep them in sight the whole time. "And if you're willing to try, we'll help you get there."

"You expect me to believe that you want one of the strongest superheroes in the world set free in the middle of a fight between our organizations?" Donald asked.

"I expect you to believe that we don't want to fucking die," Pest Control snapped back. "And for that to happen, we need some heavy hitters to come deal with these punks. Not to mention Fornax, who looks like he's

out for blood and doesn't care whose he gets. We might be criminals, but we're still people, and that means survival ranks way higher on our list of priorities than pride, pissing matches, or possible imprisonment."

Cyber Geek weighed the options in his mind. There was a chance, however small, that his gun might be able to carve a hole in the AHC's shield. But to even get to it, they'd have to get through the AHC's countermeasures, defenses specifically designed to stop a meta-human attack. Even if they made it through, the odds of the gun working were still a long shot. Just because it was strong enough to break the barrier in the game didn't mean the AHC's shield wasn't way stronger. The smart move was to lie low, keep picking off the gang metas one by one, and slowly retake control of the streets.

Except that, even if they succeeded, there would be a huge loss of life for civilians, capes, and guild members alike. Against numbers like this, everyone would end up attending a funeral. Quorum might be able to turn that around. Cyber Geek didn't know how, but the man was a legend for a reason. They needed him, which meant, long shot or not, dangerous or not, it was his duty to try and bust Quorum out.

"Fine," Cyber Geek said at last. "But I don't know you two, and I certainly don't trust you, so we're getting my team first. If it looks like you're planning a double-cross at any point, we won't hesitate to put you down."

"Get your people," Glyph said. "We've got nothing to gain from treachery, which means you're as safe as you can be with us."

"Oddly, that I believe." Cyber Geek began to turn toward Medley, but his conscience got the better of him. "You know that there are dozens of traps and countermeasures activated that are specifically designed to keep us from reaching the AHC headquarters, right? Even if you don't turn traitor, I can't guarantee your safety."

"That's fine." Glyph looked around at the fighting and madness that surrounded them and shook his head. "No, it's more than fine. It's as it should be. My teacher is the one who caused all this. If anyone should risk their life to stop him, it ought to be me."

“Thinking about redemption?” Cyber Geek asked.

Glyph chuckled and exchanged a quick look with Pest Control before responding. “Nothing that noble. No, Balaam is a traitor to our guild, so I want to see his plan fall apart, even if it costs my life, for one pure and simple reason: *spite*.”

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## Chapter 85

Wade Wyatt watched as chaos bloomed through the streets like filthy roses, blood spilling as meta fought meta and everything was hurled into disarray. The monitors all around him showed feeds not just from the news but also from private networks and security cameras, some not known of by anyone but himself.

He could see Stasis and Gork, trapped in their shared house by a combination of a giant metal wall and mystical wards. He could see Morgana, limping over the scattered pieces of Erinite, her own body bruised and battered. He could see Xelas, though that was almost always true in one way or another. He could see Balaam wading into battle with his minions, turning his magic against former allies and friends.

And Wade could see Fornax, darting between buildings at breakneck speed, trying to shatter the bones of Apollo in his bloody grip. Ivan had never been this far gone before. Not in the old days when he was slugging it out with capes for fun, not when he and Lodestar had their final battle, not even when they went against Orion for the fate of the world. All of those times, Ivan had been the one in control, using his power as a tool rather than being ruled by it. This was the first time he'd ever lost that control, and the world might be in genuine peril for it.

It was, all-around, a pretty solid plan; Wade had to give Balaam credit for that. No matter who won the brawl in the end, the capes would be weakened and have a nice public black eye, and the guild would be so crippled by losing so many members that Balaam could easily reshape it to his design. With an AHC on the mend and a large amount of meta-humans under his control, Balaam could set about wreaking true havoc, maybe even succeed in his goal of taking over a country or two.

Of course, there had been flaws in his calculations as well, the largest of which was assuming Wade would be so easy to kill. He also hadn't counted on how hard it would be to take out the rest of the council. While driving Ivan insane was a good touch, the fact that his children were

alive meant he might be able to come back around. Balaam also hadn't quite accounted for the possibility that both the guild and the AHC knew that traitors dwelled within their ranks, nor that both organizations had given them rope for the express purpose of hanging themselves. Plus, there was the giant hidden trump card he hadn't taken into consideration, though for that, he could hardly be blamed. After all, even in the guild, only Wade and Ivan knew what had really happened to Lodestar.

Wade picked up the phone and dialed a number, hoping she wasn't screening her calls. Until he'd seen Hephaestus emerge from that school, it had seemed like the only way to bring Fornax down would be with force. Now, however, there was another possibility rocketing through the sky toward him. If there was even the slightest chance they could bring him back around peacefully, if Ivan could regain control, then it was a risk worth taking. Eliminating Fornax would make the battle much easier, but *gaining* Ivan could turn the tides on a dime, especially once the rest of the council made it onto the game board.

The phone rang several times before finally going to voicemail. Wade tried twice more then considered the matter settled. It was inevitable that she would move when she saw what was happening to Ridge City. He'd hoped to catch her in time, but it seemed it was too late.

All he could do for Ivan now was hope that his apprentice was fast enough. Even if she didn't know it, Hephaestus was in a race, one for Ivan's sanity, soul, and perhaps even life. From his chair, however, there was nothing Wade could do to help her, so he turned his attention to the factors he could influence.

"I think just about every card has now been played," he murmured, checking the screens one last time. It wouldn't do to go to all this trouble and only purge a few of the disloyal members in his guild. He'd specifically waited until every other component was in motion so that he could handle this house-cleaning with only a few sweeps of the broom.

Behind him, moving seemingly on its own, the Doctor Mechanical suit came to life, walking calmly to the sole tunnel that led above ground, the only way in and out of Wade's secret bunker. The downside to meta-suits, which he hadn't realized in his youth, was that one actually had to be

inside them, and that meant losing a battle meant capture or death. It was far more efficient to simply infuse his brain with nano-transmitters and remotely control the suit from somewhere safe. Heck, he'd even gotten the programs so efficient that he could run several bots at once, a convenient way to handle all the work expected of him.

"First, I think we'll get Morgana into play," he said, carefully plotting through the possibilities. "She'll make short work of Balaam's troops and give the guild a morale boost. In the meantime, would you mind getting Gork and Stasis free?"

"No problem," Xelas replied. On camera, she stood over the broken remains of Stalwart Iron, whose voice was relaying the orders. "But I'm a little pissed you didn't tell me Stalwart Iron was one of yours."

"If I had, you might have held back," Wade replied. "And Stalwart Iron is much too valuable a mole to lose. Assuming they bother rebuilding him, I mean."

"Look, I spared the core; I'm not sure what more you want from me." Xelas looked up at the camera in the boutique, one of the few things not turned to scrap, and gave a wave. "I'll get Gork and Stasis. Have to say, though, trapping them in their own house was smart; neither of them can be hauled into a cell."

"Balaam clearly put a large amount of thought into this plan," Wade replied through Stalwart Iron.

"Yeah, just not enough to realize how stupid it was," Xelas said. "After I grab those two, do we get to go bust some heads?"

"Probably, yes. But wait for exact coordinates of where you're needed before heading in. How we respond from here depends largely on the way Fornax is handled." Wade glanced at the screen once more. Hephaestus was approaching downtown; it would only be minutes until she tracked down Fornax and Apollo.

But minutes might be too long. Once Lodestar entered the battlefield, the fight was decided. All they could do was hope that whatever



was holding her up continued to do so, for her sake as much as Ivan's. At this point, killing Fornax might be the only way to stop him.

And while Lodestar would do it to protect the world from him, burying Ivan would break Helen's heart. Especially if she was the one who put him in the ground.

\* \* \*

The costume didn't quite fit anymore. It was strange to see it pulled too tight in the wrong places. Before it had clung to her body perfectly. Of course it did: it had been made just for her, and Lodestar's body never changed. Couldn't change, in fact. But for the past seven years, Lodestar had been missing, and in her absence, Helen had grown in several places. She was going to miss the extra two inches of height she'd gained in her early twenties, and the way her waist was beginning to even out with her hips. When this was over, she'd need a new wardrobe. Thankfully, she'd boxed up all her old clothes and stored them in the attic. Part of her had always known this was inevitable, and she'd prepared for it as best she could.

Still, she had to hold back tears as she stared into the mirror, listening for the doorbell that would mark Miss Teresa's arrival. It wasn't just herself she was sad for. Helen was scared for Ivan, of whatever had turned him into the monster flying through town. She didn't know how to stop him. At least... not without permanently stopping him. He'd warned her long ago that this day might come, that the monster inside could somehow break free. And he'd told her that if it ever came to that, he was trusting her to protect the rest of the world from him.

Because only she could.

Helen also feared for Penelope, how she would react to everything. She was such a sweet, impressionable little girl. Having a mommy who was a superhero wouldn't bother her, but when she got older, and realized what the other part of Lodestar's power meant... Penelope was a good person, but finding out one's mother was immortal was a lot to lay at anyone's feet.

Of all the fears that swam through her mind as she looked at herself in the mirror, only one surprised her. Helen was feeling doubt, of all things.

She'd been out of the game for so long, and the situation in the streets was worsening by the second. Could she still do it? Could she still be that beacon for the world to rally around? Would they hate her for being absent so long? Was she so out of practice that she'd only make things worse?

Her hand tightened, and for an instant, Helen could feel the power lying just beneath her surface. It had been a constant struggle to push it down, to never call upon it even in surprise or terror. She could still remember the feeling though, the burning light that poured through her, the conviction, the invincibility. All it would take was a thought and she'd have that all again. While the other fears might come along with her, self-doubt was a worry only for Helen. As soon as she touched that power, it would fade away. Lodestar was far from perfect, but she knew her abilities and what she could accomplish. Which was, actually, damned near anything.

"Mommy, are you done changing?" Penelope called through the door.

"I... for now." There was one change left, one shift that would alter their entire lives, but it wasn't quite time for that yet. She threw on a robe and headed out the door, just missing the vibrations of her phone, abandoned and useless on her bed, as it rang with three calls from an unknown number. Miss Teresa would be here soon, and until she arrived, Helen was going to enjoy the last moments she could with her daughter.

Once that doorbell rang, things would never be the same for her and Penelope ever again.

\* \* \*

Getting downtown had been easy, assuming one didn't count the time and effort that went into making a flying meta-suit, but within moments of arriving, Hephaestus realized that talking to Ivan would be far more difficult than she'd planned. He was leaping and teleporting around so quickly that he was more hallucination than person, taking swings at Apollo as the golden man raced around at speeds Hephaestus could barely track, let alone match. No sooner would she get close to them than both would barrel off, zipping to another section of town as she did her best to play catch up.

It wasn't until the third time that she nearly intercepted Apollo, more by luck than skill, and saw him veer off that Hephaestus realized what was happening. Apollo was avoiding her on purpose. Not because he thought she was a threat—even her pride in the meta-suit wouldn't indulge that self-delusion—but because he was trying to keep her safe. The cape, however much of a dick he might be, was dangling himself in front of Ivan like meat before a tiger, hoping that no one else would be felled by its claws. It was a noble, dangerous act that nearly smacked of redemption, but it was also keeping Ivan too mobile for her to try and talk to him.

Clearly, it was time for a change in strategy. Hephaestus began to chase Apollo once more, but as she did, she also poured as much power as she dared into the speaker on the front of her helmet. There was no way Ivan wouldn't hear her, but that was all the better. The more he had to listen to, the more she might be able to reach him.

“Hey! Apollo! Slow it down!”

Ahead of her, his curly head bobbed in surprise, and he flipped over to face her for the first time. This distraction nearly cost him his head, as Ivan materialized in front of Apollo, taking a mighty swing for his cranium. A last-second dodge kept the cape in one piece, and he whipped around to swing past Hephaestus.

“Get out of here! Fornax is on a rampage. No one is safe.” This point was rather well-illustrated as Ivan slammed into a nearby building as he tried to tackle Apollo from the air.

Hephaestus caught a good glimpse of her teacher for the first time as he spun around to take new aim. Her hope of reaching him dimmed. That wasn't Ivan. Even in his Fornax days, he'd never looked like that. His bloodlust was so thick it was nearly a fog. The red runes in his eyes gleamed with madness. He might be too far gone even for her to reach. Should she have brought Rick along with her? Surely the sight of his son might have dulled the rage enough for Ivan to retake control. But as she watched him vanish, Hephaestus felt unsure. Ivan might not even recognize his kids in this state, which made it all the more unlikely that he'd remember her.

“I said run!” Apollo yelled at her from nearby, hovering and making a “shoo” motion with his hands. This time, he didn’t get away with pausing. Suddenly, Ivan was behind him, slamming Apollo out of the sky with a vicious punch to the back. A streak of light marked his fall, which culminated in a shower of earth as he slammed into a mercifully evacuated local park.

For just a moment, Ivan hung there, watching Apollo fall, and then he looked up, meeting Hephaestus’s eyes through her helmet. She could actually feel his thirst for murder rippling through her soul. Her courage nearly broke.

Then he was gone, down on the ground, standing on top of Apollo. Whatever he had planned, it was going to be brutal, and probably not take too long. Even if Ivan wanted to make it last, he was too drunk on fury. Apollo had seconds to live—at most a full minute. While Hephaestus wouldn’t be too broken up about his death, the moment he croaked, Ivan would be on the move again.

Now or never, this was the best shot she was going to get. She needed to strike... but fear made her heart waver. What would going down there really accomplish? He was so far gone, she doubted he could ever hear her, let alone understand what she was saying. Most likely, all she’d really accomplish was dying a few seconds before Apollo and everyone else that Ivan vented his perceived loss on. With the memory of Ivan’s burning eyes fresh in her mind, Hephaestus fed her thrusters, took aim, and flew as fast as she could.

Directly away from Ivan and Apollo.

## Chapter 86

The speedometer in the corner of her helmet's display read around two hundred and fifty miles per hour when she began the wide turn back to her target. Not exactly impressive by meta-human standards, but it was about as good as her current suit could handle. Maybe later, if such a time existed for her, she'd look into ways to put more oomph in her rockets. Right now, this was the best she had. It would just have to be enough: for her and for Ivan.

Hephaestus tore through the air, adding a few more miles per hour now that she was on a direct course. She was rapidly approaching the park where she could now see Ivan looming over Apollo, who looked a lot bloodier than he had less than a minute before. She poured on the speed, locking on to her target and refusing to falter. If she paused now, even for a moment, her courage might never rekindle enough to go through with this idiotic plan. It occurred to her that this might be a good time to say a prayer, but since the man she was racing toward proclaimed to have eaten a god, Hephaestus wasn't quite sure how much good that would do or who would be listening. Instead, she stretched out her left arm, said a silent apology to the suit she'd worked so hard to build, and phased completely into fire-form.

Like the left hand of a vengeful god, Hephaestus rocketed down from the sky and smashed directly into Ivan's face, fist-first. Her gauntlet and most of the left arm shattered on impact, sending her reeling through the air for a brief instant before she went crashing across the park's well-cared-for grounds. Sparks flew and countless warning screens flashed in her helmet; the meta-suit had just taken far more damage than she'd built it to withstand. Hephaestus didn't wait for it to finish bounding across the grounds; already turned to living fire, she slipped free after the second bounce, reforming to a human-shape as she took in Ivan and Apollo.

The cape looked far worse than she'd seen from above. His legs and right arm were broken, and she could see ribs sticking out from his torso's

tanned skin. It had been less than a minute and Ivan had done so much damage—too much longer and she’d be looking at a corpse.

Broken as Apollo was, however, he was not her central focus. Ivan stood over the fallen hero, but Tori realized with a combination of joy and terror that she’d succeeded in turning Ivan’s head. It was probably more out of annoyance than pain, but she’d done it: she’d gotten his attention. Now she just had to make good use of it.

“Ivan, it’s me.” Her eyes scanned the streets and sky, but no cameras were in sight. Not really a surprise. Ivan and Apollo had been hard enough to follow with a flying suit; the average news van didn’t have a shot in hell. “It’s Tori. Your kids are safe. The building didn’t hurt them; I got them out in time. Rick and Beth are safe.”

Those glowing, terrible eyes lingered on her for a few moments longer, then began to turn back to Apollo. Acting on sheer instinct, Tori hit Ivan in the face with a torrent of flame. It surely didn’t hurt him, but it was bound to be bothersome. At this point, she’d settle for pissing him off enough to make him listen.

“Listen, dickhead! I didn’t race across Ridge City twice, stand under a falling building, and crash my suit just so you could ignore me.” She ceased her attack, and, in what she could only hope wouldn’t be the dumbest mistake of her life, shifted back to a full human-form. What did it really matter? Ivan could kill her either way. She still wore her Hephaestus mask, the only piece of the costume she’d had time to slip on before donning her suit, but otherwise she was clad in her usual sweats and t-shirt that she pattered around the lab in. It left her feeling a bit idiotic, like a child playing dress-up with a mask rather than a certified villain, but she pushed that feeling away. This was not a time for doubt. Costumes didn’t make the meta.

“Are you listening to me, Ivan? Ivan Gerhardt? Father of Rick and Beth Gerhardt, who are both *still* alive. Get your shit together, Ivan. You would never let me slide for going this far out of control. You’d smack me on the back of the head and mutter about the importance of keeping one’s power in check. God damn it, Ivan, you don’t get *months* of being that smug and proper only to lose your shit like this.”

To her surprise as much as anyone's, it was working. The personal attacks kept Ivan's shining eyes focused on Tori, rather than Apollo. He was listening, which was good; she just didn't know if he was hearing her. What little optimism she possessed wavered; Ivan had shifted toward her and drawn back his fist.

She knew that stance. It was the one he'd used on her the very first time they met. He'd held back as much as possible before punching her, and even though she was in fire-form, he'd still nearly killed her. If he let loose as things were now, she'd be lucky if there was even enough pulpy residue left of her to bury.

"Oooh, getting aggressive. Am I supposed to be scared?" She was, in fact, terrified, and it was only thanks to Ivan's self-control lessons that she kept her voice from quivering. Showing weakness was a luxury she couldn't afford. Not right now. "Can you hear me in there, Ivan? How are you going to explain to Rick and Beth that you killed the nice young woman you introduced them to? Because that's something you'll have to do. They're alive, you willfully-deaf bastard!"

Those damn eyes were locked on her and the fist tightened. If she hurried, there might still be time to run. Probably not far or fast enough, but it could buy her a few more precious seconds of life. The human brain, even a meta one, was hard-wired for self-preservation, and in that moment, any action that might allot her a few more moments of breath seemed like utter brilliance.

"You won't attack me." She sounded a lot more sure than she felt, but given that she was standing instead of running, perhaps she was surer than she realized. "You can't. I am a full member of our guild, and I have done nothing wrong. If you strike me, you break the code. I don't care how pissed you are, I don't care how much control Ivan's lost. He won't let you do that. Ivan loves that damn, annoying, fucking code more than anything except his kids. He won't break it. He won't kill his own apprentice. He—"

Without her suit, Tori couldn't even see the movement, but as a blast of wind struck her, she thought for an instant that she'd been wrong, that Ivan had hit her, and that he had done so with such power that she only registered the force, not the pain. But then she saw his hand, still balled into

a fist, fewer than two inches from her stomach. His face was directly in front of her, and it was no longer smiling. Now it was pinched in visible pain as an internal war waged inside him.

Reaching down slowly—the last thing she wanted was for him to think he was under attack— she laid her hands on top of his quivering fist. “Ivan. It’s okay. They’re safe. But the city is going crazy. You once told me that Rick saved the world because he gave you the desire to protect it. Well, right now, they need you to save their home, to make sure they stay safe. They need you. I need you. The whole damn guild needs you. So please, quit fucking around with the pity party and get your ass back in the driver’s seat.”

His eyes closed for barely longer than a blink, but when they opened again, they were different. They were still black with the red runes in place, but the gleeful shine had gone out of them. A small tear made its way from the right eye, leaving a trail of smeared blood as it fell down his face. Bit by bit, the fist in her hands opened, and finally gave her fingers a light squeeze.

“Tori... thank you.”

It was only when she heard his voice that Tori let out the breath she’d been holding since she landed. Ivan was back. The day was far from over, and they still had a lot of shit to slog through, but just knowing her teacher had returned made the idea of it all the more bearable.

“Yeah, well, you technically saved my life once. I’m not big on owing debts.”

“I meant for saving my kids,” Ivan replied. “Though keeping me from killing everyone in the state is also appreciated.”

“The state? You were that off your rocker?” Tori asked.

“If anything, I’m being conservative in my estimate. There are certain aspects of my power I might not have told you about.” Ivan looked down at his hands, almost as if he were realizing for the first time that they were coated in dried blood. “I was just so mad when I saw that school go down. What about the other children inside?”



Tori looked away from Ivan for the first time since she'd landed. Before a word left her lips, one of his blood-covered hands fell gently on top of her head.

"Forgive me. That wasn't a fair question to ask. I'm sure you did all that you could. Those who were lost are not marks on your soul. That honor belongs to the ones who endangered them in the first place." Ivan turned from Tori to Apollo, who was slowly trying to stagger to his feet behind them.

"Ivan..." Tori warned.

"Don't worry. I've got control of myself again, and I won't be letting that go anytime soon. That said, I am still rightfully pissed off, and I feel that Apollo has some explaining to do." He looked past Tori to the dented and smoking remains of her meta-suit. "Think your Hephaestus model will still function?"

"Maybe. Took a hell of a beating coming in, but most of the damage was confined to the left arm."

"Go see if you can get it up and running," Ivan ordered. "Apollo is going to fill me in on exactly what's happening, and then we're going to start the counterattack. Murky as the last half hour has been, I still recall seeing hordes of crooks roaming the streets, attacking our people. As a councilor of the guild, that is something I simply cannot allow to stand."

"So Fornax isn't done for the day?" Tori asked. Though the words came out teasing, there was a serious undercurrent of fear beneath them.

"Fornax is long dead; today he was only briefly resurrected. No, my actions now will simply be as the guild guard dog."

"Maybe I should call you Spot, then," she replied.

"That sounds like the sort of joke Balaam would make. I don't plan to be nearly that lovable." Ivan turned to Apollo, who'd managed to brace himself against a tree and was watching the exchange with a mix of relief and confusion. "Think less Lassie, more Cerberus."

\* \* \*

Dapper Doll struggled under the weight of the multi-armed meta-human that had pinned her to the street. She'd made it through ten gang members before this one had caught her from behind, twisting her limbs before she could counter. Struggle as she might, without the ability to move her hands, she was nearly powerless.

Her attacker used one of his two free arms to pull out a long, dangerous-looking knife.

“Always wanted to see what was under that pale skin.”

At those words she redoubled her efforts, but it made no difference. The weapon inched closer to her stomach. She was seconds away from wearing her guts on the outside when a red blade burst through her attacker's throat. No... that wasn't right. It came *out* of his throat, along with two more from the back edges of his neck. His eyes widened as the three blades made a single circle, sending his head toppling down onto her chest.

The scream left her throat before she realized it would be more prudent to keep her mouth shut, given that the exposed neck would be showering her with blood in seconds. That shower never came, however. Blood fired up like a geyser, rising through the air until it flowed into a thick, red bubble oozing down the street. As the blood vacated her dead attacker, a small symbol flickered into view below the remains of his neck, glowing for less than a second before it faded from sight. Dapper Doll shoved the corpse off her, careful to avoid the knife, and pulled herself up to see what was happening.

All along the street, gang members were sinking to the ground, heads neatly parted and blood draining from their bodies. Every drop of it flowed toward a figure walking calmly down the street. Her raven-black hair was held back by a helmet which matched her armor, all the exact color of the blood seeping out of her headless victims. She paused her saunter to reach into the bubble of red liquid that trailed her. When her hand emerged, it gripped a massive scythe, far larger than she should be able to wield, and the bubble grew a bit smaller.

Turning with her new weapon in hand, she and Dapper Doll at last locked eyes. Her gaze housed a pair of sclerae that were full of blood, long

streams of it running from their corners and soaking her face.

“Morgana La Faye. The Blood Witch,” Dapper Doll whispered. Though this particular villain had come along before Dapper Doll joined the AHC or was ever a meta-human, she was still famous, even decades later. With the power to manipulate blood, even as it pumped through other’s bodies, she was regarded as one of the deadliest meta-humans in known history. While others might have been stronger, Morgana could kill with a single thought.

“I thought you were dead.” Dapper Doll wasn’t sure if she was about to die or not. The adrenaline from her last encounter was still tingling in her veins as she stretched her fingers and prepared to go down swinging.

“Get ready for a lot of that today,” Morgana replied. Her voice was surprisingly pleasant, given that she was walking amid a sea of corpses that she’d created. “But you don’t need to be so tense. My orders are to deal with the violent criminals. Capes are off-limits unless they make themselves a nuisance.”

With the body of her would-be killer still laying at her feet, Dapper Doll felt certain that she’d rather have the Blood Witch on her side, at least until they restored some order to the streets. Maybe someone could bring her down later—Erinite didn’t have any blood, so he could give it a shot—but Dapper Doll getting beheaded in the street wasn’t going to help the AHC or Ridge City.

“With you as backup, I think we’ll make short work of this,” Dapper Doll said at last.

Morgana smiled, a feature that would have seemed gentle if not for the bloody tearstains framing her face. “I am only the first of our backup. Rest assured, very soon Balaam’s followers will see why our guild has so few uprisings.” She swept her blood-scythe through the air, testing its heft.

“This is a mistake that I will make sure no one is ever stupid enough to repeat.”

## Chapter 87

Chloe didn't really have much of a plan as she raced forward, watching with wonder as Beverly clotheslined both of the bigger metas into a wall. Even the fire-pants thing had just been a stroke of luck. How could she have known that the woman in the weird dress and shoes would be a braggart? Still, she would take luck over nothing, especially after watching that woman kick a freaking dragon across the street. One of those attacks and Chloe was a goner. She really needed to think of a phrase that lent itself to being indestructible. Especially as she ran forward with no actual idea of how she was going to stop this woman.

The fire was slowly going out; Chloe's best guess was that it needed fresh lies to keep it fueled. Nevertheless, her enemy was still distracted. With nothing else up her sleeve, Chloe decided to play the odds. If she was making a stupid, suicidal rush anyway, she may as well get some cosmic aid on her side.

**"Fortune favors the bold,"** Chloe whispered. Instantly, the flames upon woman's leggings went out. She looked around in surprise just in time to see Chloe run up and shove her in the chest. It was a lot like shoving a brick wall and had the predictable result of sending the barista sprawling to the ground instead of her intended victim, arms already going numb from pain.

"Well... I suppose that happened." That darling smirk was back in place as the woman moved her platform shoes closer to Chloe's splayed form. Behind her, Beverly was fighting for all she was worth, slowly getting the upper hand. The other two criminals would probably be down soon. Just not soon enough for Beverly to help save Chloe.

Desperately scanning her surroundings, Chloe looked for anything she could use to defend herself. All that was in arm's reach was the parasol fancy-dress lady had dropped when her legs caught fire. If it had been powerful enough to stop Beverly's claws, it might be enough to ward off one of those deadly kicks.

“I can see what you’re thinking, but don’t bother.” The woman’s voice was sickly sweet and teasing, like she was explaining things to a toddler. “That weapon will only serve its master. In fact, I think I’ll—”

Just as she reached toward the parasol, which had begun to float up from the ground, her wolfman accomplice was hurled away from his fight and slammed into the back of her knees. She windmilled her arms, trying to catch her balance, but the ground beneath her had been shattered by the earlier fighting and gave way, tipping her forward.

Warning forgotten, Chloe grabbed the nearby floating parasol and tried to use it as a shield to keep the powerful meta from falling on top of her. For all she knew, the lady in the dress weighed ten thousand pounds and that’s why she was so strong. The parasol refused to open, though Chloe kept struggling with it until she felt a sudden pressure slam down on top of her.

Staring down at her from only a foot away was the heavily made-up face of the woman, whose pink and black dress was now stained with fresh blood. She’d fallen forward, directly onto the unopened parasol, which had run straight through her chest. Over the woman’s shoulder, Chloe could just make out what appeared to be most of a heart wedged on the parasol’s tip.

It was impossible to say which of them was more shocked by the turn of events. The woman’s shaking hands began to rise, curled into claws meant to grab Chloe’s neck.

“You... bitch... kill... you...”

As the hands grew closer, Chloe tried to twist away and accidentally succeeded in the task she’d failed before. The parasol opened, seemingly unbothered by the body wrapped around it. Instantly, the woman was gone, replaced by a rain of gore as her torso was disintegrated by the suddenly-expanding parasol. Chloe clutched the murder weapon over her head, trying to stay safe from the brief downpour of blood and organs. Somehow, she succeeded, and when the last of the splattering stopped, she pulled the parasol away to see that she, and somehow it, were both unstained.

“Holy shit, Chloe.” Beverly slammed the bug-eyed meta down on her knee, eliciting a loud snapping from its spine before tossing it to the

ground. “Do you have a phrase for making people explode?”

“N-n-no.” Chloe’s body was so full of adrenaline that her teeth were chattering. The urge to vomit kept rising from her stomach; only force of will and a healthy amount of denial kept it in check. “I-I just got lucky. I was bold.”

“Yeah, I’m going to want some explanation on that later. For now, are you okay?” Beverly stepped over the bloody legs that were all that remained of the woman and the unconscious wolfman to kneel next to Chloe. “Did you get hurt?”

“Just my arms a little, when I shoved her.” Chloe could barely feel the pain anymore, though she knew it would come shooting back when she finally calmed down. “I think I want to go home now.”

“Probably a good idea,” Beverly agreed. “Are you okay to get there by yourself?”

“Sure, **it’s just a hop, skip, and a jump away.**” Chloe slowly pulled herself to her feet, using the parasol as a cane. When had it closed up again? She didn’t remember pulling it down. Then again, her mind wasn’t exactly running on all cylinders at the moment. “Do you want to come too?”

“No, I can hear more fighting going on,” Beverly said. Her green scales were beginning to turn white, and already her body was shifting in size. “I’ve got a guild to look after.”

“Be careful,” Chloe warned, though seeing as Beverly had actually won her fight and Chloe had just gotten lucky, she wasn’t sure why she was worried about the dragon.

“You too,” Beverly replied. Then she leapt into the sky, newly grown wings catching the air. In a few flaps, she was gone.

Chloe looked down at the parasol still in her hands. It was oddly comforting, but also a reminder that she’d accidentally killed someone. Gently, she laid it down near the legs of its original owner, and then did her hop, skip, and jump back to her apartment.

She made it back safely, which was nice. Somewhat less comforting was her discovery that her entire apartment building was currently engulfed in flames, with a whole section already caved in. She stood on the street, staring up at her burning home, racking her brain for a saying that would put out fire. When her eyes finally left the building, they found a new, somehow more disturbing sight.

Resting against a busted mailbox, just within arm's reach, was that same pink and black parasol.

\* \* \*

“Down!”

Cyber Geek fell to the concrete seconds before the laser blast burned through the air above him, saved only by Medley's warning. He jerked his gun upward, trying to find the automated cannon that they'd caught sight of, only to discover it was already frozen in an unmoving hunk of ice. Just for good measure, he squeezed off a few shots to destroy it completely, then got back to his feet slowly in case any more traps had been activated.

Between the energy fences, automated cannons, sizable attack-robots, and sonic tasers, their group was looking pretty roughed up. It was only by luck and persistence that they'd made it so far—at least one of them had had the power to handle every trap they'd encountered so far, which had bailed the less-well-equipped out. Cyber Geek was beginning to see why the defenses worked the way they did: almost every meta had some weakness, which the traps would eventually hit. But if a team came through, they could cover each other, which meant AHC members could eventually power past if needed. Of course, that worked off the assumption that criminals were loners, which was proving to be shockingly untrue in light of the day's events. Still, the guild might be more anomaly than rule.

“We're getting close.” Hat Trick limped as she spoke; the large tear in her sparkling pants almost hid the burn mark on her leg where she hadn't quite dodged fast enough. Cyber Geek's esteem for their newest teammate had risen; in the time since she was injured, not once did she hint at the idea of turning back.

“Which is both good and bad. There’s a reason we had to keep civilians several blocks back. The farther in we get, the more dangerous it is.” Medley was largely unharmed, though that was thanks only to his healing and toughness. The truth of the matter was that he’d easily taken more blows in their trek than anyone else, throwing himself in harm’s way to keep everyone else safe. Without Medley, Cyber Geek doubted they would have ever made it this far—not with all of them still breathing, anyway.

“At least we’re alone,” Pest Control pointed out. He was right, too. While the gang members might be spread across town causing trouble, none of them were stupid enough to actually try and approach the AHC headquarters.

Nope, only Cyber Geek and his friends/temporary non-enemies were idiotic enough to take on that sort of task.

They reached an intersection that marked the last street between themselves and the AHC headquarters. While the dome stretched down around the building, the outer fences and gates were still unshielded. No one needed to say what they all knew: the lesser defenses were the ones that had been tucked away on public streets. On their own property, the AHC had no doubt constructed one hell of a counterattack system. As soon as they got closer, something was going to trigger, and none of them had the faintest idea what it would be or if they could survive it.

“You could shoot from here,” Cold Shoulder suggested. “I mean, you’re obviously close enough to hit.”

“If this thing works, the most it will do is make a hole,” Cyber Geek told her. “We’ll still have to get up to the dome to go through. So I may as well be right next to it to give the charge as much oomph as possible.”

“How many of those barrier breakers do you have?” Hat Trick asked.

“The game only gives you one because that’s all you’re supposed to need.” Cyber Geek cycled through his ammo options, confirming the lone shot as he spoke. “Technically, I can get more by dismissing this blaster and



pulling out a new one, but that's going to take a lot of time. Way more than we probably have."

"In that case, let's make sure your first shot does the job." Glyph walked over to Cyber Geek and held up his wand with the glowing purple tip. "With your permission, I'd like to put a rune on your gun."

"What will that do?" Medley didn't actually step forward, but the slight lean to his stance made it clear that he could be on Glyph in the span of a heartbeat.

"It should give his shots extra power, though I confess I've never tried using a power-augmentation rune on a gun summoned out of a video game. It's supposed to be for weapons, brute strength, and spells. But it works on mundane firearms, so the principle is sound," Glyph said.

Cyber Geek considered the offer, carefully examining the weapon still clutched in his hands. Even aside from the risk of treachery on Glyph's part, which was a very real possibility, mixing meta abilities was dangerous stuff. Technically, neither Cyber Geek nor anyone else at the AHC had figured out what made his power work, and if it was some method that reacted poorly to magic, then adding a rune could dissolve the gun, or blow it up, or any other outcome. However, it could also make the difference they desperately needed. Maybe he could punch through the AHC's dome on his own, but that seemed pretty unlikely. If Glyph could give them even a slightly better chance of succeeding, then it was worth taking the chance.

"Go for it," Cyber Geek said. Glyph didn't hesitate, drawing a strange symbol on the gun. It began to glow in mere seconds. When he stepped back, Cyber Geek cycled to the blaster's standard destructive ammo and let off a few test shots into the street a few feet away.

The ground exploded into miniature craters, sending dust and debris spraying up into the sky. "Looks like it works on the small scale," Cyber Geek noted.

"We'll have to hope for the best on the barrier breaker," Glyph replied. "Thank you for trusting me, by the way. Right now, I don't even think many members of my own guild would do that."

“You keep doing right by us, and we’ll keep giving you the chance to prove yourself,” Medley replied, though it was hard not to notice the way his claws flexed as he spoke.

“All right, time is against us, people; we need to get a move on.” Cyber Geek did a quick sweep to make sure everyone was ready and found that all five of the others were attentive and resolved. All they were waiting for was his order. For a moment, he wondered when exactly he’d become the default leader of their group; Medley seemed like a far better fit for the role. It was something he’d have to contemplate later, though, as right now, they were looking to him. He had to fulfill the role.

“Everyone stay safe, prepare for anything, and watch each other’s backs. Now, let’s move!”

\* \* \*

A soft blue glow surrounded Miss Teresa, matching the one that those with the right sort of meta-senses could see surrounding Helen’s house. Her eyelids slowly pulled themselves apart, and she gave a weary nod to Helen and Penelope.

“The barrier is created. Only you, I, and Penelope will be able to pass through, at least until someone manages to overpower it.”

“Which has almost never happened in our world’s history,” Helen replied. She laid a hand gently on the older woman’s shoulder. “Thank you so much for this, Teresa. I know it takes a lot out of you, but I couldn’t... with the way the city is, I had to make sure she was safe.”

“Silly girl, how many times have you saved the entire planet?” Teresa said, swatting the hand away in a manner that somehow still managed to be affectionate. “I owe you my life and the lives of everyone I love. If I can help, I must. And what’s more, I take pleasure in it. Even if I wish it were for a happier occasion.”

Helen nodded. On the television, news crews had stopped showing the fight between Fornax and Apollo, which she hoped meant Ivan was back under control. Regardless, it didn’t change the essence of her duty. Capes, guild members, and common meta-criminals were all brawling in

the streets. Professor Quantum seemed to be giving as many shits as usual when a situation didn't directly affect him, and Quorum was stuck in the headquarters building. Ivan had done a good job for a long time, but the day had finally come. There was no getting around it, no one to cover for her. The world needed a hero.

It needed Lodestar.

Bending down gently, Helen took her daughter by the shoulders and looked her in the eyes. "Penelope, Mommy has to go out for a while. And when she... when she comes back, she's going to look a little different. But I'll still be me, okay? I'll still be me, and I'll still love you more than anything. So don't be scared."

For all the cheerful flippancy Penelope usually showed, her face was abnormally serious. She leaned forward and wrapped her arms around Helen's neck, hugging her with all the strength her tiny body could manage. "I won't be scared. I'll never be scared of you. I love you, too."

Helen wanted to cry, but instead she just embraced her daughter, savoring the last moment of normalcy they would ever truly have. Then it was over, and the hug broke apart. "Go over to Miss Teresa, honey. She'll keep you safe while I'm gone."

Penelope did as she was told, making her way slowly over to Miss Teresa, who gently took the small girl's hand. Helen looked at them both and smiled with a joy she didn't really feel. She took several steps away. It had been a long time since she did this; she needed room to work in. Standing ten feet away from Miss Teresa and Penelope, Helen reached into herself for the power she'd been pushing down for nearly a decade.

It flowed through her instantly, suffusing her body with the same energy that the comet had crackled with as it came down on top of her. Her skin glowed as her chestnut hair turned a translucent-white. Beneath her closed lids, her irises shifted to a stark lavender that was both gorgeous and terrifying to see. Most striking of all, however, was the change that rippled through her actual flesh. Her muscles toned, her spine shrank, and small details altered all over her face as the last seven years melted away. Helen could age normally if she didn't call on the power, but Lodestar was forever nineteen, trapped in the day the comet hit her, and when the power faded,

that's where Helen would be again. Just one use of the power, and her whole body reset.

As she gazed out about the room, she saw Penelope peeking in wide-eyed wonder at her. Part of Helen had been terrified that no matter what promises were made, Penelope would be afraid when she saw who her mother truly was. Instead, her daughter looked awestruck, like a priest given a glimpse of their god.

"Be good for Miss Teresa, and you two stay safe," Lodestar ordered. She took a few steps, noting that once again her costume fit perfectly. "There are people out there that need Mommy's help, and she's already kept them waiting for much too long."

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## Chapter 88

Putting together this much chaos had, humorously enough, taken a ridiculous amount of forethought and planning. Gathering the guild members who could be trusted, secretly reaching out to the most vicious meta-human gangs that hadn't been wiped out, and, of course, getting everything coordinated with Apollo... all of it had just been so much work. Yet as Balaam made his way through the streets, watching buildings lit on fire and capes struggling to beat back a horde of destructive criminals, he felt the warm glow of satisfaction that told him it had all been worthwhile.

The glow was aided by the ripples of power that were flowing into him, coming faster by the minute. Hunting down the Brand of Kurmtis had taken him years—he'd begun the task long before the signal was ever given to actually start the ball rolling on today's festivities—and it had been time well-spent. Even the effort of convincing the gangs to let him use it on them, annoying as it had been, was paying off. And he hadn't lied when he said that being branded would give them a bit of an increase in their power. He'd just skipped over what the other, more important side effect was.

Nearby, a cape that Balaam recognized as Kicknominal delivered a strike that sent an acid-breathing meta-human in a leather jacket careening through the air to where they landed hard on the ground. Though Kicknominal didn't notice, the impact broke the acid-breather's neck. On the exposed flesh just below the break, Balaam saw one of the countless Marks of Kurmtis flicker as its true purpose took effect. Moments later, the power of the dead criminal flowed into Balaam, and he suppressed a shiver of delight.

All these criminals killing themselves off, just for him, and with every death, his magic grew a little bit stronger. It was a ritual sacrifice, one they didn't even know was taking place. Only a few minutes into the fray and Balaam's skin was already tingling with new power. By the time the guild finished wiping out all his pawns, Balaam would be the most powerful meta in history: stronger than Fornax, or Doctor Mechanial, or even Lodestar. He would be unstoppable.

It would be good to be so powerful when presiding over his new guild. If things were going to plan, the *true* members were getting their recruitment speech right about then, and while everyone would agree to join, there would doubtlessly be a power struggle. With this new fuel, he would easily crush any opposition and take his rightful place as their ruler.

Kicknominal, having finished with the lesser criminals, took off toward Balaam, no doubt intent on doling out more physical punishment. Balaam gave a minor wave of his staff and Kicknominal literally exploded from the inside, sending a spray of his internal components across the street.

Balaam looked from the cape's remains to his staff and back again. "Huh. Guess I've got more power than I realized." Just for good measure, he gave it another wave and finished off the gang members that Kicknominal had subdued. They burned to ash in seconds, and an instant later, Balaam felt their energy come rushing in.

Every little death helped, after all.

\* \* \*

The left arm was shot and several of her systems were offline, but to Tori's surprise, the meta-suit wasn't completely a lost cause. She scrapped the rest of the left arm and sealed the gap with a focused flame, a terrible attempt at spot welding that would just have to suffice until she could get it to a lab. Having no room for an entire arm would have been a serious issue if she weren't free to reshape herself as living fire. It took some wiggling and a few tries, but eventually she managed to rise from the ground once more as Hephaestus, albeit Hephaestus with a lot of bangs, dings, and one arm fewer. Her legs were barely functioning as well, though only able to take small steps, but mercifully, the flight system still worked. While there wouldn't be any more hairpin turns, she could still take to the air.

In the few minutes it had taken her to get back into the suit, Apollo had filled Ivan in on everything: the plan to cause a revolution, Balaam's betrayal, Balaam's *second* betrayal where he'd brought in dozens upon dozens of metas to fight both the AHC and the guild, and, of course, Quorum's incarceration. Ivan took it all relatively calmly, though Tori

couldn't help wondering if that was only because he'd already beaten the living hell out of Apollo and doing more would just be excessive.

"What's the plan?" Hephaestus asked, slowly making her way over to them. The legs were going to need to be rebuilt almost from the ground up. Actually, by this point, that might be true of the entire suit.

"Clearly, Balaam expected me to be a bigger distraction, that I would keep the strongest of the AHC's forces occupied as I killed them off one by one," Ivan said. "But since that's no longer the case, I think the capes will be able to rally and take control of things, eventually. Our guild is no doubt also getting into gear; once the councilors arrive, it will take less than an hour to purge the streets of every low-level meta who thought to raise arms against us."

"So, that's it? Turning you back gave us the win?" Hephaestus asked.

"No. That's what bothers me. Even if you hadn't gotten through to me, it was only a matter of time before Lodestar would have arrived and removed me from the equation. Sooner or later, Fornax was going to be out of play; there were just too many ways for it to happen for Balaam not to have accounted for that. He's a bastard and a traitor, but he's not stupid. We have to assume the best of our enemy in order to not be overtaken by him. So, if Balaam knew I'd eventually stop rampaging and the guild would mount a counterattack, what does he gain by having his forces wiped out?"

"I know I'm not exactly the most trustworthy person here, but have you considered the possibility that these aren't all of his forces?" Apollo asked. "As someone who actually sees the numbers on this stuff, there are a *lot* of low-level meta criminals out there. This might seem like a big chunk, but it's barely the tip of the iceberg. And that's not even counting the bigger fish we've already locked up in Rookstone."

Ivan's eyes went wide, a very disconcerting image since his face was still plastered with blood. "That's it. Balaam doesn't want a gang of incompetent street-level crooks. He wants a guild strong enough to rival ours. And there are only a few places in the world with enough criminal meta-humans who have that sort of power. Imagine how grateful the worst of the worst in Rookstone would be to get suddenly handed their freedom."

“Rat bastard,” Apollo spat. “He’s keeping us distracted. With the AHC on full response and the building sealed up, the security at Rookstone is minimal. Even if a distress call went out, we might not get it. But how can he be there and here at once?”

“We know he’s turned some of the guild against us, why not more?” Hephaestus said. “Not everyone would have been in the base when your people attacked, and of those missing, I’ll bet a few are with Balaam, helping with the breakout. He might have cherry-picked the gang members with potential to help out too. While he puts on the show, they do the real work. It’s actually standard guild tactics, when you think about it.”

“Somehow, that pisses me off even more,” Ivan said. “We need to ruin his plan.”

“I can fly to Rookstone,” Apollo offered. He caught sight of the skepticism in Ivan’s bloody face and quickly continued. “Look, we both know I’m done no matter how this plays out. Between your guild and the AHC, there’s no place I’ll be able to run. I messed up big time, and I’ll have to pay for it. That said, Balaam screwed me too, so if I can spend my last hours as a cape repaying the favor, I’d like to do it.”

Ivan looked at Hephaestus, who gave a small nod. Apollo might be a piece of shit, but he was a fast one and had the right connections to perhaps make a difference. “Fine,” Ivan said. “Go now. Keep Rookstone secure. We’ll find and stop Balaam.”

Apollo’s golden glow began to return, and he lifted slowly off the ground, hovering for a few seconds before firing off into the sky. They watched him go, the small streak of light fading into the distance. Within seconds, he was out of sight, and soon his light trail had vanished as well.

“Think he’ll be able to handle it on his own?” Hephaestus asked.

“If the jailbreak has already started, then it’s doubtful. That’s assuming we were even right about Balaam’s plan. It’s entirely possible that he’ll arrive and find nothing out of place. But if we were right, then he’s in for a hell of a fight.”



“At least he’s strong,” Hephaestus said. “Not Fornax strong, obviously. You whipped the shit out of that guy. But still... strong. Maybe he can handle himself.”

Ivan shook his head. “Some of the meta-humans in Rookstone were put there by the sole cape that *could* beat them. Apollo is good, but there’s only one Lodestar.”

“Um, yeah, speaking of, do you see that?” Hephaestus pointed into the sky. What appeared to be a second sun was falling downward, burning so brightly that it seemed like the very heavens were crashing upon the Earth. Ivan had once told her there was no feeling like seeing Lodestar descend, and as the burning ball came further down, she finally understood. There was something about it, something impossible to describe, but when she looked into the light, Hephaestus knew beyond any doubt that the woman within was on a whole other plane of power.

To her surprise, she felt Ivan stiffen as he watched the light descend. His head fell several inches, and a slight whisper escaped from his lips. “I’m so sorry, Helen.”

Hephaestus decided that this was probably not something she needed to comment on, at least not while a giant brawl was still going on, so instead, she slapped Ivan on the back with her suit’s remaining right arm. “Since Lodestar is here, I doubt we’ll have to mess with the small fries much. Let’s go hunt down a traitor.”

“I like that idea,” Ivan said, raising his head once more. For a split second, she thought she saw the wild grin try to slip back into place, but then it was gone, if it had ever really been there in the first place. “I like that idea very much. Let’s go remind Balaam what happens to those who break the code.”

\* \* \*

Greasy Gary, a nickname that had stuck with the slimy crook since falling into a radioactive oil puddle had turned him into an ever-slick meta-human, tripped as the others turned a corner. He was a few steps behind, as usual, but it would be fine. With his gang, they were unbeatable, and they’d

taken down three capes already to prove it. He slid around the corner, expecting to see Tam and Kel punching people into submission.

Instead, he rounded just in time to see Tam's skull get vaporized. She fell to the ground, one more headless corpse on a growing pile. With horror, Greasy Gary realized that those bodies belonged to the rest of his gang. But... how? Ten seconds. That's how far behind he'd fallen; ten seconds, at most. What on earth could have mowed through them with such incredible speed?

His answer came with the sound of more shots being fired, and for the first time, Greasy Gary looked upward toward the source of the noise. Hanging there by means of the jets firing from her feet was a metallic woman with cannons on each arm, blasting away. There were also guns poking out of her back, chest, and a pair framing her head as she spun slowly in place, shooting without error at every single non-cape or guild meta-human on the street. She'd just turned away as he came into view, which was likely the only thing that had saved him from sharing the others' fate.

Greasy Gary didn't waste his chance, spinning around and dashing back down the alley he came from. Was that someone in a meta-suit? If so, they'd put a weirdly expressive face on the front. He could have sworn that thing was smiling as it killed wave upon wave of metas. To be fair, even if he were a better student of history, Greasy Gary likely wouldn't have recognized Xelas. She'd been through many an upgrade since leaving the public eye.

Running back to the street he had just left, Greasy Gary skidded to a stop just as a hybrid car crashed to the ground near him. Another flew through the air, smashing into a small cluster of other criminals that had been trying to flee. It was impossible to miss the one doing the throwing: a giant creature with stone gray skin was easily hefting parked vehicles and tossing them at every criminal in sight. One brave group of metas tried to charge it, and they were quickly smashed into putty beneath its giant hands.

The sound of a rocket drew Greasy Gary's attention upward again. The unmistakable form of Doctor Mechaniacal soared through the air, firing a laser that neatly sliced in half everything and everyone it touched. More

split-open corpses tumbled to the ground, small bursts of light flickering on their necks as they passed from one world to the next.

This... this was insane. Balaam had assured them they'd have the upper hand, that their numbers would let them take the capes by surprise. Greasy Gary slid backward, hoping to get out of sight, and bumped into an unmoving figure behind him.

"You all really put your dicks in a hell of a beehive." A dainty hand grasped his shoulder. Greasy Gary tried to slip away but the fingers didn't budge, not even as he secreted as much oil as possible. It was such a gentle grip, just firm enough to hold him in place, but nothing he could do made the fingers even so much as twitch. A new hand came around from behind, carefully slipping itself across his throat.

"Honestly, did you all really believe Balaam when he told you that you could win? Did you never stop to question just how we'd held our position on top for so long? I'm disappointed, more than anything. I'd really hoped that the class of common criminal was a little smarter than this." The grip tightened, and much as he clawed at it, Greasy Gary couldn't get it to lessen. It was like the woman behind him didn't even feel his struggling. She didn't even seem strong. Just... immovable.

"Then again, maybe what we're seeing is natural selection at work," she continued, even as the pressure on his throat built. "Surely there were some of you smart enough to reject the offer. Maybe we'll be able to fish out of those pools for future members. And if not, if all of you were really so stupid to believe you could stand against our guild and survive, then at least the example we make of you will ensure the next generation makes smarter choices."

Stasis realized that midway through her speech, the slimy man in her hands had gone unconscious. She kept her grip for a while longer, making sure the deed was properly done as Gork and Doctor Mechaniacal swept up the rest of the street. Nearby, she could hear the screams of Xelas and Morgana's work. They needed to hurry things along; everyone had seen Lodestar drop into the heart of downtown minutes prior. Once she took control, the capes would start trying to take prisoners, and by that point, it

might be prudent for legendarily dead or wanted criminals not to be so visible.

Her hands opened and Greasy Gary fell limply to the ground, one more dead body to show everyone what happened when people crossed the guild. Stasis stepped over him, looking for another straggler to pick off.

There was so little time to work with, and such a big message to send.

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## Chapter 89

Lodestar was a blur as she whipped through the streets, striking every meta-human throwing punches with a careful two-fingered strike to the temple. It was a technique that had taken her years to master, reigning in her tremendous strength to deliver a non-fatal knock-out blow. Despite her fears that she would be out of practice after so long on the sidelines, her form was still perfect as she downed criminal after criminal. Professor Quantum had once speculated that no amount of control should be able to produce such an effect, and that her technique only worked because she believed it should. It had been in one of their many discussions and speculations about the exact nature of her powers, and while she never entirely agreed with his theory, she was thankful for the ability to bring people down without killing them no matter what its source.

Of course, not every meta-human was so easily felled; as she zipped into a crowd swarming a cape, her first attack bounced harmlessly off a thick skull. The man whirled around, showing his bulging bones and misshapen muscles. Not all meta-humans got to keep their appearances when the change came, and it was no wonder someone who looked like this had decided to take it out on the world. He reared back and threw his fist at her, no doubt failing to recognize just who he was attacking. Lodestar caught the blow easily in midair, then punched him in the head again. This time, she used a fist rather than two fingers, and he slumped to the ground in a limp heap. She preferred to be gentle whenever possible, but time wasn't on her side.

Moving swiftly, she began knocking out the rest of the group, leveling bodies so quickly that she soon revealed their target: a crouched figure clad in an eggshell-colored meta-suit. Sparks and dents came off it as the familiar figure of the Whitest Knight rose from his knees and stared at his savior.

"Holy crap! Lodestar... you've come back." Even through the metallic hood that covered his face, she could see the shock in his eyes.

Without so much as a pause, Lodestar drove her fingers through the metal helmet, cracking Whitest Knight on the skull and sending him tumbling limply to the ground, his breath shallow but constant.

“*Whoops*, guess I didn’t notice you were on our side. That sort of thing happens when you insist on dressing like a racist di-, um, jerk.” Lodestar looked around to see if there were anyone to witness her words, only to realize she’d already knocked them all out. There was almost no chance she wouldn’t get some heat for that, but she’d do it again if given the chance.

The area around them had been almost completely emptied as Lodestar tore through, felling opponent after opponent. Now that she was on the ground, however, her enhanced senses could pick up far more details than she’d seen on the news. The criminals were being beaten—murdered in the streets, really—as the guild’s heavy hitters finally showed up for a counterattack. The rest of the AHC was regrouping—evacuating citizens, capturing gang members, and minimizing the destruction before fires or collapsing buildings could cause any more casualties.

Outside of her immediate vicinity, about a mile or so away, she could feel Ivan as he raced across the city blocks. If a meta was powerful enough, they created a sort of ripple she could sense, though usually only when she was looking for it. What surprised her was that he was on a crash course for someone else strong enough to be felt. Balaam, probably, but since when had he ever been this powerful?

She was tempted to hurry over and help but decided against it. For one thing, Lodestar and Fornax fighting together, especially after the latter went on a rampage, would raise a lot of questions in the public’s eyes. Things were already going to be bad when this was over; the AHC would need a few capes who could prove they still deserved the public’s trust. More important than that, though, going over would be poor resource allocation. Ivan could handle Balaam, even if the mage was sporting some extra mojo. She should focus on making a difference elsewhere.

With the streets falling in their favor, the logical step would be to break open the dome and go get Quorum. Much as she trusted Ivan—and Wade to a lesser extent—having all of the guild’s councilors on the streets

felt a bit disproportionate. Better to have another legend alongside her, something to encourage them to not get ambitious when the common enemy was defeated. Besides, she trusted Quorum's judgment, and he'd no doubt have insight on how to properly quell the fighting.

Moving at speeds that left her looking like a blur, she raced through the streets toward the AHC headquarters, pausing for milliseconds to knock out every criminal she met along the way.

\* \* \*

The explosion blew off Cold Shoulder's arm. Or, rather, it blew off the arm of the ice construct she was currently encased in, sending freezing shrapnel across the battlefield. The mine launcher spun around from its armored bunker on the ground, taking aim at her once more.

Cyber Geek dashed forward and jammed the barrel of his blaster through the small slot in its hull, firing off several rounds until the mechanism stopped moving. The strategy worked, but in trying to pull his gun free, he realized it was stuck. Not a good sign: being stationary in this fight could very well cost someone their life.

Everything between the AHC's gates and energy dome seemed designed to kill intruders. More laser cannons had sprung out to fire at them, this time joined by small nodes that blasted everything around them with enough electricity to stun an elephant and almost enough to stop Medley. There were more attack-robots as well, along with new toys like the mine-firing systems which were too accurate for anyone's taste with explosions that were almost impossibly disproportionate to the mass of the fist-sized mines. The worst of it was the unseen system above them, though, well-positioned on nearby buildings or some satellite in the sky. All they knew was that if they stood still for too long, blue bolts of piercing energy would rain down. Medley had taken the first of them and gotten a dime-sized hole through his shoulder. Since then, they'd made a point of staying mobile while fighting their way closer to the dome.

Cyber Geek kicked on his suit's thrusters, giving himself enough force to pull the gun free mere seconds before one of those blue beams hit the ground where he'd been standing. Sweeping around, he scanned as he ran to see who needed help. As deadly and insane as the situation was, there

was also an odd sense of familiarity to it. How many times had he guided digital avatars through situations just like these? Keep the party alive, minimize damage, meet the target goal; he'd drilled for this countless times at his computer. Yes, the stakes were much higher and the skills needed were far different than when it was pretend, but the strategic part remained the same.

Hat Trick used her multi-colored scarves to cover the camera-eyes of an attack robot, allowing Medley to sink his claws into its metal hide and tear out its innards. Pest Control was swarming the cannons with his wasps, digging them into the circuitry and slowly destroying the guns from the inside. Glyph stood behind the cover of Cold Shoulder's giant ice construct, but he was doing far more than merely taking cover. His wand swished through the air; when he stopped, a new rune glowed on the lower calf of Cold Shoulder's frozen armor. Instantly, the ice darkened several shades. The next attack failed to do more than even chip the exterior. Cold Shoulder returned the blow, shattering the offending robot into debris with a single blow.

Just as Medley pounced onto a laser cannon and Hat Trick filled a mine-shooter's bunker with playing cards, Cyber Geek saw a path. It was thin and risky, but his teammates and the two villains had successfully managed to open a small avenue forward. Donald would have debated the idea, wondering if they should keep pushing back the forces to try for a more secure opportunity, but Cyber Geek didn't have room for hesitation in his plan. He barreled forward, cycling through ammo options as he ran. The rune from Glyph still glowed on the side of his gun, and as the icon with only a single bullet appeared in his display, Cyber Geek said a silent prayer to the gods of video games that this would work.

He darted past Cold Shoulder, who threw an arm out to intercept another mine before it could land and explode in his path. This time, the explosion only took off some of her icy fingers. She stomped the bunker down with the new magical strength in her frosty legs. Medley darted ahead, triggering an electric node that Cyber Geek had missed and then crushing it in his claws despite the voltage racing through him. Hat Trick flipped her top hat around, unleashing a dule of doves that flew above Cyber Geek's head. Their beating white wings probably weren't that strong,



but hopefully they'd offer enough cover from the sky beam for him to take the shot.

Then, almost at once, he'd arrived. The crackling energy of the dome was only inches away from him, a barrier strong enough to keep out meta-humans far more powerful than some upstart with video game powers. Much as he might have liked to indulge in self-doubt, it would have to wait. Right now, his team was counting on him. Cyber Geek raised his gun, got it as close to the dome as he dared, and fired.

A blast of purple energy erupted from his gun, slamming into the yellow barrier with a symphony of hisses and pops, like a computer shorting out from a voltage spike. The collision burned with a phosphorescent glow, forcing him to turn away. When he was finally able to look back, Cyber Geek could barely believe what met his still half-blinded eyes.

It had worked. There was a human-sized portal in the barrier, tinged with purple edges, just like it was in the game. He'd managed to break through the AHC's dome, something designed by *Professor Quantum*, using only his power and a little extra juice from Glyph. Cyber Geek spun around to tell the others, cycling back to regular ammunition so that he might eventually cover their run to join him. But as he turned, he realized that while he'd been burning a hole in an impossible barrier, the entire landscape of the battlefield had changed.

Everything was broken. Every robot, cannon, mine bunker, electric node, and even the massive drone that accounted for the strikes from above, all of it was shattered and spread out in front of the AHC headquarters. The only things still standing were his teammates, the pair of surprisingly helpful villains, and... Lodestar.

She ignored the awed stares from the others, who were no doubt partly wowed by her legendary status as much as the destruction she'd visited on obstacles they'd seen as deadly. With a brisk pace, she walked over to Cyber Geek and examined the hole in the barrier.

"Did you do this?"

“Yes, ma’am. I mean, I did, I’m sorry, but we needed to get to Quorum, though I know I probably shouldn’t be breaking the barrier. I just —”

“Relax.” She held up a hand to quiet him, attention still on the break he’d created. “I’m not mad; I was going to shatter the thing anyway. I’m actually impressed. There are a few metas who can overpower the field, like me, but breaching it like this was supposed to be impossible. Professor Quantum is going to be annoyed that you showed him up, and that’s a show I always like catching.”

“I... thank you. Ma’am.” It felt strange to be saying ma’am to someone who looked half a decade younger than he, but there was no doubt in Cyber Geek’s mind who was more senior. He’d seen pictures of her flying around since he was a child, though she’d appeared older from a distance.

“Thank you, this saves me some time,” she replied. “Tell your team to get inside; most of you need medical attention, and we’re already well on our way to taking back control of the streets.”

“Yes, ma’am. Um, what about the two villains? Am I... should we bring them in?” Cyber Geek dearly hoped she wasn’t going to say yes, but at the same time, he couldn’t very well hide the fact that he’d led criminals up to the AHC’s front door.

“The warrants issued to arrest the guild were provided under false evidence created by Apollo. By now, I bet they’ve already been suspended. So far as we know, those two were just a pair of meta-humans in the wrong place at the wrong time. We are the law’s enforcers, not the law itself, so I can’t see any reason to detain those two young men, especially in light of the assistance they offered.” Lodestar turned back to the starstruck capes and motioned for them to come forward. All three complied, while Glyph and Pest Control headed back out toward the street.

As they were leaving, Cyber Geek caught Glyph’s eyes and gave the fleeing villain a small nod. There was no doubt these two had been at the museum robbery, but Lodestar was right: they didn’t have any proof or warrants, which thankfully meant there were no grounds to arrest either

villain. One day they might have to meet one another again as enemies, but Cyber Geek would be content if that moment never arrived.

Now, the dragon and Hephaestus who'd humiliated him and Medley, those were different stories. But as Hat Trick limped forward and Medley weaved about, Cyber Geek's mind fell away from things as petty as revenge. He had a team to take care of. That was his real job.

Cyber Geek ran to his team, dropping his gun and letting it dissipate, then sticking an arm around Medley and Hat Trick, helping them both through the hole in the barrier. Cold Shoulder was on Medley's other side in a moment, doing all she could to support his sizable mass. By the time the hole in the barrier collapsed, they were all safely inside, and Lodestar was on her way to free Quorum.

It wasn't until several hours later that Donald remembered he was supposed to have a coffee date with Tori, though he took comfort in the fact that he had one hell of an excuse for missing it.

## Chapter 90

Part of Hephaestus wanted to be surprised that amid a sea of battle, blood, and chaos, Balaam was waiting for them in a small park, an island of tranquility maintained only by his power. But she wasn't. It was the sort of piss-poor theatricality that wannabes like him reveled in. He'd probably picked the spot out ahead of time, selecting it specifically in case Ivan managed to regain control, knowing full well that he would be the first target of Ivan's wrath.

Ivan didn't seem fazed by it either, his face inscrutable under the thick coating of Blunderbuss's blood. She'd sort of expected him to wipe it off after coming to his senses, but he'd left it in place, perhaps for intimidation, or simply because he didn't have a mask with him and this offered at least some concealment. As she started forward, he held up a hand in front of her.

"This is as far as you go." Ivan turned to her, somehow staring into her eyes through the helmet between them. "He's dangerous and even stronger than normal. I don't want you getting hurt."

"What the hell? Why did you tell me to follow if you weren't going to let me help?" Hephaestus demanded.

"Because your suit is one good punch away from falling apart, and if I hadn't dragged you along, you probably would have thrown yourself back into the fray." Ivan smiled—not the wild, deadly grin of Fornax, but the gentle, wheedling smirk of her teacher. "And besides, I assumed you wouldn't want to miss this. Or would you rather just *hear* about my fight with Balaam?"

"Okay, point taken. I guess it will make for a good show," Hephaestus agreed.

"I'm sure it will; just don't try to become a participant. No matter how things go." The smile faded, and Ivan looked as serious as he had on the first day he'd warned her about messing with his children. "I've already

lived through the pain of losing family once today. Don't make me repeat that experience."

Before she could respond, Ivan was gone, walking across the street to the modest park where Balaam waited patiently. The sorcerer seemed to be all but glowing with power, waiting as Ivan stepped onto the soft grass. Hephaestus backed up several feet, then thought better of it and flew upward, landing on top of a nearby building with perfect line of sight of the impending show.

"Should be quite interesting."

The voice had come from behind her, and Hephaestus whirled around to find a pair of kaleidoscope eyes looking past her to where Ivan and Balaam were slowly drawing closer. Nexus ignored the gauntlet she had pointed toward him, stepping to the edge of the roof for a better view.

"Even imprisoned, Quorum made quite the difference. His words softened Apollo, and his imprisonment gave the AHC hope that he could be freed. Although you showed some rare results as well. Generally, when you try that plan, Fornax kills you. You aren't a unique by any means, but you *are* interesting, Hephaestus."

She was tempted to press for more, to find out what Nexus knew, but Stasis's face flashed before her eyes, that look of lost terror when she'd talked about dealing with Nexus. No. Hephaestus didn't need his kind of knowledge, and it didn't matter, anyway. Whatever other versions of her he was talking about were irrelevant. She wasn't any of them. She was her own Hephaestus, with her own path to forge. And she was going to start by bearing witness to Ivan and Balaam settling their score.

"Why don't you shut it?" Hephaestus snapped at Nexus. "My teacher is about to whip the shit out of this traitor, and I want to enjoy every minute of it."

\* \* \*

Ivan came to a stop twenty feet away from Balaam, who hadn't moved once during the approach. His red irises were gleaming with a power that poured off him in waves, like heat from summer asphalt. While Ivan

didn't know exactly how Balaam had gained such a dramatic increase in his power, it didn't surprise him. If he didn't think he had the upper hand, Balaam would never have allowed himself to be found. The man was a snake, but also an experienced strategist and a survivor. Even now, seemingly ready for a final battle to the death, he no doubt had a few dozen tricks up his sleeve.

"Pity. I thought I'd be facing Fornax," Balaam said, breaking their silence.

"I'm sure you hoped for it. A brainless monster you could use your magic to outwit, maybe even trick into serving your purposes. No, Balaam. No Fornax for you. No Pseudonym either. Today, you fight the man whose guild you betrayed, whose apprentice you ambushed, whose children you tried to murder. Today, you fight Ivan Gerhardt, and he has no mercy in his heart for you." A nearby tree wilted as Ivan's power fluxed slightly out of control. All that lecturing to Tori about keeping her heat in check, and here he went and let such amateur mistakes happen. Truly shameful.

"Loud barking as always, but I wonder how you'll back it up without Fornax's bite." Balaam turned his staff through the air, pointing it at Ivan. "That version might have been a brainless monster, but we both know what he's capable of when properly harnessed. You're in a precarious position. Hold back and you'll die; use too much power and the real you will shine through. Show him to me, here and now, because it's your only chance at survival. I'm too strong for even you right now. Ivan cannot defeat me. Fornax might have a chance."

"That's your problem, Balaam. You always thought Fornax was the more powerful one. You never understood that control is far more important than brute strength." As Ivan spoke, runes covered his skin for the second time that day, dark magic bubbling to the surface. He drew it forth carefully, in far smaller amounts than earlier. It wasn't like before—at least, today's before. No, this time the power served Ivan, not vice versa, and he could think of far better ways to use it than taking wild swings at his target.

"Well then, let's see you put—"

Balaam's reply was cut off as Ivan slammed his foot to the ground, sending out a wave of energy that had the dirt erupting from the ground in a

massive brown cloud. Balaam fell back immediately, raising a spell of protection with a single flick of his staff and preparing a magical blast for his counterattack. The dirt swirled, twisting and expanding, blocking any view of his surroundings. After the first ten seconds passed without an attack, he switched tactics, summoning a mighty whirlwind that blew away enough dirt for him to see. What met his eyes was Ivan neither lining up an attack nor moving into a defensive position.

Instead, Ivan had his hands pressed to the ground, muttering under his breath as magic poured out of him. Balaam fired the blast he'd prepared, but it was too late. Ivan leapt aside, letting the ground scorch in his place. A ripple of red energy flowed outward from the spot he'd been touching, across the park's grounds and up into the sky, forming a perfect half-sphere around them.

"A ward? You cast a *ward* in the middle of a fight? Half of your fighting style revolves around short-range teleportation!" Balaam's smug veneer vanished as he probed the barrier sealing him off from the outside world. It was rudimentary but strong. Busting through would be no small task.

"I didn't want you trying to cast a teleportation spell if things didn't go your way," Ivan replied. "Like I said, Ivan is far more dangerous than Fornax. He knows how to anticipate his enemy's plans. Though that's not to say Ivan can't also get into the fray, when properly motivated."

While he didn't actually vanish—his magic barred such techniques from him as much as Balaam—Ivan did close the gap between them so quickly that it almost seemed like teleportation, striking at the sorcerer with a blow powerful enough to have knocked Apollo off course. His fist slammed against a different kind of barrier, though, one that flashed into existence several inches in front of Balaam's face. The sorcerer didn't waste the opportunity, jabbing his staff into Ivan's ribs and sending him tumbling several feet back.

"You must have put a lot of magic into that thing," Ivan remarked, rubbing his side. It didn't hurt, just mildly tingled. Balaam may wield enough force to move him, but injury was a whole other matter.

“I have spent decades reinforcing every enchanted item I own, and with today’s ritual, I can fill them with more magic than I ever dared dream.” The air around Balaam flickered as large, bat-like wings grew from his back. The shadows at his feet rose from the ground. “Come and see what a true master of the arcane arts can accomplish.”

Ivan watched as Balaam’s spells snapped into effect one after the other. Protection charms, shielding magic, metamorphosis, shadow-summoning, fire-warding, and a dozen smaller ones that Ivan didn’t even recognize. By the time it was done, Balaam the sorcerer was unrecognizable. He’d turned into a winged demon hovering in the sky, surrounded by flaming orbs and dozens of sharp-clawed shadow minions. This was Balaam as the capes had once fought him, a master mage whose talents had earned him back his freedom when a stolen artifact threatened the world. This was Balaam at the strongest they knew of him, and Ivan was certain that there was still more to be seen.

With a small exertion of will, Ivan called on more of the dark power buried in his soul. Around him, the grass died and the ground splintered. This was dangerous; he’d already used too much of the magic earlier in the day. Bringing forth too much could cost him his control once more. Still, he pushed on, determined to see this feud finally drawn to a close. His rune-covered eyes met the burning irises of Balaam, all that was recognizable in this new form aside from his staff, and Ivan smiled with perhaps just a hint of Fornax shining through.

“Show me what you’ve got. Show me *everything* you’ve got.”

\* \* \*

One by one, the guild members were disappearing from the streets. Johnny Three Dicks and Thuggernaut finished off a small cluster of crooks then hopped into a sewer entrance tucked inside an alley. Glyph and Pest Control were ambushed by a gang of eight, which would have been a real issue if a giant white dragon hadn’t landed nearby, quickly turning green and evening the odds. Minutes later, they were clutched in the once-more-white dragon’s claws, being flown out of town as fast as she could flap. The Bytes found a fast food restaurant with free Wi-Fi and minutes later were



picked up by a town car service, all being addressed by new names that matched their fresh identities.

Morgana was the first of the councilors to disappear, simply walking down a dark alley and not emerging. A lovely woman with raven-black hair did come out the other side; however, since she wasn't surrounded by blood or wielding a scythe, no one paid her much mind. Xelas vanished next, literally turning invisible after she paused long enough to pick up Gork and Stasis. Soon the three of them were tearing through the sky toward a safe house. Doctor Mechaniacal was the final member to depart, seeing things through to the end. Only when the vast majority of gang members were dead or apprehended and when the capes began to look at him with increasing scrutiny did he activate his own shielding system and fly away.

He did linger long enough to see Lodestar and Quorum out on the streets together, organizing the broken ranks of the AHC superheroes and spearheading the organization. Neither of them would give the order to fire on him, at least not today, but tensions were running high all over Ridge City. A secret guild of villainy had been uncovered, a trusted AHC leader turned out to be a criminal, thousands of civilians were dead or injured, and the city was facing millions in property damage. It wasn't the sort of place that was secure for a meta without AHC approval. It might not even be safe for the capes, once the dust settled.

Scanning the area as he moved, Doctor Mechaniacal made certain that every guild member he'd been tracking was out of the brawl. Some were in custody, arrested before Balaam's betrayal, but he would free them through the legal system—already he had lawyers ready to tear apart the false case Apollo had built against them. Others were dead, killed by capes or gang members—it was impossible to tell. They'd done their best to make Balaam's pawns pay, and there was little sense in trying to pay back the AHC for anyone they'd killed. Capes would be going in the ground too; this day had left a wake of loss for everyone. Better to put them back on the path of peace, if it was possible. Otherwise, there would just be more graves to dig before all was said and done.

Just to be on the safe side, Doctor Mechaniacal took the long way around Ridge City, making sure that none of the countless capes had the ability to track him back to the lair where his fragile human body was

waiting. This route had the added benefit of taking him past the riverfront docks, where he caught sight of a remarkable ship pulling into harbor. It was massive, protected by an energy field and spinning turrets, fashioned from a material not even his sensors could identify. There were only a few people in the world with both the mind and the resources to create a vehicle like that, and since Wade hadn't done it himself, that narrowed the list considerably.

Unless Tech Lord had found a very well-paying job or Tyranny had decided to leave her nation to invade foreign soil, it looked as though the Champions' Congress would soon be in complete attendance for the first time in over a decade.

Professor Quantum was back in Ridge City, and that presented a slew of problems all its own.

## Chapter 91

Of all the abilities Ivan had—and there were more than anyone else actually knew about—flying wasn't among them. True, he could cast a spell of flight that allowed him to slip the bonds of gravity, but the process felt unnatural and gave him a queasy stomach. Flying simply wasn't in his repertoire, which was why he used a different method to take to the skies as he cannonballed around the park.

Ivan leapt through the air, twisting about and conjuring a small circle of force beneath his foot when he wanted to change direction. Using it as a midair stepping stone, he would thrust off with his incredible, magically-augmented strength. While the method was imprecise, that flaw could be compensated for through lots of training, which Ivan had certainly acquired in his more mischievous days.

This method also had the benefit of making his movements unpredictable, which was clearly frustrating Balaam to no end. He threw spell after spell at Ivan, only for Ivan to jump out of the way at the last moment.

The shadow minions clawed at the tatters of Ivan's suit as he moved, shredding what remained with their knife-like claws. He smacked them away off-handedly, destroying the annoyances easily. They were meant to distract him, not to do real damage. Balaam knew his opponent wouldn't be defeated by minions.

On the other hand, Balaam's fire wards were causing Ivan more trouble. Whenever he managed to duck an attack and draw near, one of the burning spheres would launch itself between him and Balaam and then explode. They didn't do much damage, but the burst was enough to let Balaam slip away. The sorcerer was employing a smart, strategic method. Ivan's weakness had always been that he lacked much in the way of ranged tactics—the few spells he had took too long to cast, and Balaam knew how to ward against them. To finish the fight, Ivan would need to get in close, and that was exactly what Balaam was preventing. He probably planned to

keep firing long-range spells, wearing Ivan down bit by bit until either the ward or Ivan fell.

Ivan landed on the shattered ground of what had once been a lovely downtown park, though it was no longer recognizable as such. Now the grass burned, the earth cracked, and the few surviving trees were warped and misshapen. This whole place would be the magical equivalent of a toxic spill-site for years to come; Ivan's wards were the only thing keeping that energy from leaking out into the rest of the nearby city. They couldn't go on like this for long. Sooner or later, the capes would finish up their work, and when they arrived, Balaam would try to use them as hostages. That was assuming they didn't come for Ivan first, since he was still wearing the blood of a murdered cape on his face. No, he couldn't let Balaam have his way.

Above him, more flame spheres dripped from Balaam's staff, replacing the ones Ivan had already detonated. Shadows reformed, pooling into bigger, hungrier monsters. Balaam flapped a bit farther away, keeping a wall of defenses between himself and Ivan. Despite all this casting, his magic didn't appear to be depleting in the slightest. Whatever source Balaam had drawn from, it clearly wasn't running dry anytime soon. Tiring him out was off the table.

The whispers in his ears grew louder, and Ivan pulled more power from within. It was restless; having tasted freedom so recently left it stirring for more. Part of his brain filled with gleefully bloody images, but Ivan shoved them aside. He had the focus of battle upon him, and the weight of those counting on his victory helped him stay in the proper mindset. All along his skin, the etchings glowed brighter.

Balaam's staff was pointed toward him, a spell like black lightning glowing on its tip. He would release it any second, forcing Ivan to dodge, to stay off-balance. All his little tricks to manipulate the battlefield. All the scheming and thought. Ivan would have found it impressive were it not turned against him. Instead, he just saw them as petty, childish tricks. Balaam had wanted to see Fornax so badly, to reach the same legendary status as his idol.

It was time to show Balaam exactly what a legend was made of.

This time, when Ivan leapt up from the ground, it crumbled beneath him, leaving behind a small crater where nothing would ever grow again. He soared upward on the momentum of his jump. Balaam grinned as he fired off the spell. Ivan could see it now—Balaam knew Ivan would dodge. His spells were meant to control him, not injure. They'd both been trying to wear the other down before attacking in earnest. The difference was that Ivan knew how to discard a plan when it wasn't working anymore.

Ivan wove a shield of magic around his arm before throwing it in front of him and taking the black lightning's strike just below the wrist. Pain—how long had it been since he felt *that*?—burned his flesh, yet Ivan's course didn't waver. The shadows sprang forward from the sky, but this time, he didn't let them get close. Ivan released a pulse of the dark magic that dwelled inside him. For a moment, the whispers were so loud he couldn't think, but then mercifully faded. Short as it had been, the pulse was enough to rend every one of the shadows apart; they fell to the ground, twisting and burning as they landed.

Balaam's altered face wasn't smiling anymore. He waved his free hand, putting all of the flame spheres between him and Ivan. Rather than take another shot with his staff, Balaam turned upward toward the ceiling of the ward trapping them. It didn't take much to figure out his plan: Balaam wanted to knock Ivan away and then break through the barrier. Once he was free, he could slip away. He'd be free to do more scheming and attack from the shadows. He'd be free to come after Ivan's family again.

"No, Balaam. We finish this today."

The first sphere hit Ivan dead in the face, but he conjured more discs of force beneath his feet and shoved off just as the shockwave struck. It took almost all of his strength, but he pushed through, refusing to be knocked aside. Regular fire couldn't touch him, but the magical flames burned at his clothes; some were even powerful enough to singe his flesh. Ivan paid the charred skin no mind. His eyes were on the next sphere, ready to jump through it, and then the next, and the next. Ready to do whatever it took to stop Balaam for good.

Later, Tori would describe it as seeing the flaming visage of Death burst forth from within the final sphere. Ivan had fought his way through

five of them—five that had burned his skin and turned his clothes into scarcely more than ash. His undergarments survived, thanks solely to the fact that a life in villainy had taught him the importance of extra-durable boxers, but otherwise, all that could be seen was fire, skin, and blood as Ivan sprang through the final explosion.

From Ivan's perspective, all he saw was a tremendous amount of fire, and then suddenly a demon slicing at his barrier with its staff. Balaam was so focused on the task that he didn't even notice Ivan until the man's bloody hand closed around his gray, muscular shoulder. Balaam's head, now with a thick brow and a pair of horns atop it, whipped around to find Ivan staring at him, strands of hair smoking and the blood burned to a copper-brown on his face.

"First off, you have a terrible idea of what real demons look like." Ivan's punch landed directly in Balaam's face. Whatever protection the demonic form offered, it wasn't enough as the two went tumbling down, Ivan refusing to yield his grip now that he finally had the sorcerer in his clutches.

"Secondly, you would dare turn on our guild? After everything we did for you?" This time, the punch was to the stomach just as they were landing, putting Balaam's gut in a pincer maneuver with the earth. Though he was coughing in pain, Balaam swept his staff around, trying to knock Ivan away and regain his distance.

"Not happening." Ivan caught the staff in his free right hand and wrenched it from the sorcerer's grip. With a mighty squeeze, he snapped it in half, letting loose an explosion of magic that left everything up to his forearm smoking and bloody. The staff's destruction caused Balaam to ripple as his demon form melted away and revealed the familiar face of the guild's traitor.

"How did you—"

Ivan jerked Balaam up from the ground before he could finish, clenching the gory remains of his right arm into a fist once more. "Third, you tried to kill my apprentice. My student. My friend." This time, there was a scream, along with a bloody stream of vomit, when Ivan slammed his fist into Balaam's stomach.

It was so loud, in fact, that Ivan didn't hear the sound of his own barrier being broken.

"Your organs are more pulp than anything right now, but I'm sure you've got enough magic left to keep yourself alive, so let's move on to your biggest mistake of the day." Ivan reached forward and wrapped his fingers, some of which were so sliced up from the exploding staff that he could see the bones, around the top of Balaam's head.

"Please, Ivan, we can make a deal here," Balaam pleaded, the blood of his vomit staining his teeth red. They matched his irises.

"*Four*, you tried to murder my children. We're both going to hell, Balaam, but you're going today." Ivan tightened his fingers and began to squeeze when a gentle hand fell across his forearm.

He was so shocked to see someone else there, his powerful wards effortlessly destroyed, that he nearly flexed his fingers and ended Balaam quickly. Only Ivan's exceptional self-control kept his grip steady as he turned to look at who had made it through.

"Ivan, your anger is righteous, and you have undeniable cause to kill this man. But while you only believed your children dead, others are not so lucky today. Please, if you will, I ask that you yield his punishment to me."

If he'd been asked a moment prior, Ivan would have said there was no one else in the world he would allow the pleasure of killing Balaam. But that would be because in his rage, he'd forgotten one of the guild's most quiet, dangerous, merciless members. Kristoph stood before him, all sense of childlike wonder wiped from his face, his hand resting on Ivan's battered forearm.

Balaam looked between them, the resignation of death quickly turning to panic. "Wait! Wait, I didn't kill them. That was Bombastic; I made sure he was the one who did the deed, not me."

"And he is answering for his sins," Kristoph replied. "But it is the fault of the man who wields the knife, as much as the knife itself, when a life is taken. You gave the order, Balaam, and now your soul bears the mark

of your sin. But I will not steal from one with a righteous claim to vengeance.”

Behind him, Ivan could hear Hephaestus land. Some apprentice, ignoring his explicit directions yet again. She was safe, as were Rick and Beth. When this was over, no matter what happened to him, Ivan would go on knowing the people he cared about were okay. But from what Kristoph said, not everyone in town would have that comfort. Balaam had robbed at least a few parents of that, and tempting as it was to crush his skull, that torture would be short-lived.

“Kristoph, I’ll yield my claim to you on one condition: nothing quick. Make him suffer.”

“He will taste a hundred times the agony he has unleashed upon the world.”

“Still feels low, but I guess it will have to do. He’s all yours, Kristoph. I yield my claim of vengeance to you.” Ivan released Balaam, who tried to scramble away, waving his hands in a desperate attempt to call forth a magic that would see him to safety.

Kristoph simply shook his head. “No magic can save you now.” From his back, the pair of wings began to grow, stretching into the sky. But they were not the bat-like wings that Balaam had fashioned for himself, nor were they the fluffy white wings that people associated with angels.

No, Kristoph’s wings were made of blades. Stained straight razors, chipped scissor halves, rusted butcher’s knives, they all rattled in a soul-quaking symphony as they stretched behind him, drops of blood falling from each of their tips. Slowly, Kristoph reached down and plucked up Balaam from the ground as if he weighed nothing at all. With a look to Ivan over his shoulder, Kristoph flapped those nightmarish wings once, and the two of them were gone.

“Um... Ivan.” Hephaestus approached his side slowly, as if she was afraid Kristoph would reappear to snatch her as well. “Do we really have no idea what Kristoph is?”



“He’ll tell you, if you truly want to know,” Ivan said, flexing his hand and realizing for the first time how much it hurt. It would be at least a day before the thing was fully healed, maybe a day and a half. “But no one ever does.”

“Then, how do you know he’ll tell you?”

“Xelas asked once, back when we first found him and figured out what he did,” Ivan explained. “She took him into a room and politely asked for an explanation of exactly what he was and how his powers worked. And he told her, after which Xelas went straight to Doctor Mechanical and had him purge the memories of the entire day from her hard drive. All she would say is that there are some things she’s happier not knowing about the world.”

“Xelas did that?” Hephaestus looked at the empty spot where Kristoph and Balaam had vanished. “Yeah, I think I’m okay with that bit of mystery in my life. What’s the plan now?”

“The capes are probably restoring order, which means we need to be out of here before they start wondering about that guy who was beating the shit out of Apollo,” Ivan said. “I’d like to get home, take a shower, and then go check on my kids.”

A sound like worried breath being let out through someone’s teeth, and then run through a voice distortion program, came from Hephaestus’s helmet.

“Yeah, about that shower. I might have forgotten to mention that before I went to save your kids, there was something of an... incident at the house.”

\* \* \*

Apollo saw the smoke before he ever got close enough to make out details, but he still held on to hope. An attack was always possible; it didn’t mean the jailbreak was successful. He doubled down on his speed. The worst of his injuries from the fight with Fornax had already healed, which allowed him to fly faster as he raced the trouble that Rookstone was facing.

It was a race he'd lost, he discovered as he floated down to find whole sections of the upper jail destroyed or burning. The few guards who were still alive were seriously injured, and even with swift medical attention, making it through the night looked to be a long shot. Apollo canvased the area as fast as he could, searching for any sign of the criminals that had caused such damage. When none met his eye, he found the door to the lower cells, the giant vertical tunnel where the more powerful metas were stored. Normally, one needed clearance from three different sources to access the area. That was less true today, as the massive door had been blown apart, leaving a giant hole into the prison's depths.

Apollo descended carefully, for not even he could take a whole jail's worth of metas on by himself. A few guards were still alive, and it seemed like a majority of the cells had gone into automatic lock-down mode. Some were ripped open or just unoccupied without explanation, but plenty others still had their prisoners safely stored inside. He continued to go lower, all the way down to the bottom of the shaft.

His greatest fear was confirmed as he landed. All of the cells here were empty, torn apart through various means and emptied of their contents. This had been the true target, the bottom floor, where the most dangerous metas ever captured were stored. Some had been powerful enough to wipe out entire cities in the fight to bring them in.

And now, because of a plan he'd played a part in, they were all loose on the world once again.

## Epilogue

“The jailbreak wasn’t a complete success in that many of the less-powerful prisoners remain, but in terms of freeing dangerous metas while simultaneously making us look incompetent, it did a five-star job.”

Professor Quantum flipped through the report, sitting where his remote terminal had once been. Three days after the battle for Ridge City and they’d finally finished putting together a comprehensive report of the damage, coupled with exactly who’d been sprung from Rookstone. Unlike Quorum and Lodestar, who sat across from him, Professor Quantum was actually marginally showing his age, a smatter of gray salting the temples of his dark hair. Otherwise, he looked exactly the same as he had for the last several decades, even wearing the lab coat he sported in place of a cape.

“Do we have any idea what they’re up to?” Lodestar asked. “Balaam was going to lead them, but since our reports say he was... extradited... that seems unlikely.”

“We’ve gotten a few accounts of sightings and smaller jobs from across the globe,” Quorum told her. “The best guesses of our analysts are that without Balaam as a uniting force, they’ll probably all scatter and hatch their own plans. Few of them were ever team players to start with.”

“Which makes hunting them down all the more difficult.” Professor Quantum turned a page, a motion that Lodestar and Quorum followed. While it was tempting to dwell on the jailbreak, they had a lot to get through; besides, with no information to work on, they would just be spitballing. The chance to recapture the freed metas would come eventually. They just needed to be patient and prepared.

“On the subject of team players, I trust you all have noticed we’re being barraged by lawyers regarding bids for the freedom of the few guild members captured during the fight. This seems utterly mad to me, seeing as we have record of them fighting against AHC-sanctioned superheroes on dozens of cameras.”

“They’re claiming they were exercising their right to resist an unlawful arrest,” Quorum said. “And since every bit of footage we have shows them merely trying to incapacitate, even against some of our more aggressive, newer members, they’ve got a very strong case. Add in Apollo’s confession from two days ago confirming that the warrants were based on falsified evidence, and our own lawyers don’t think we have much chance of making any of the charges stick. If anything, we’ll be lucky not to be sued for wrongful arrest, though thankfully, we’re insulated for excessive force.”

“We must have something to throw at them that will stick.” Professor Quantum lowered his papers, looking between his fellow members of the Champions’ Congress. “I don’t agree with his methods, but Apollo was right to be bothered by our tolerance of known criminals. He’s presented us with a golden opportunity to topple that guild, and I simply cannot believe we have to let it slip away.”

“They’ve already taken some serious blows,” Lodestar replied. “Several of them died in the fighting, their headquarters was broadcast on international news, many of those thought to be dead were caught on camera, and to top it all off, the world now knows their organization exists. He shone a giant light on the shadow where they hid, and that’s going to make things a lot more difficult for them in the future.”

“Which may not be entirely a good thing,” Quorum added. “With so many less-restrained villains now running about, we might have benefitted from the quiet peacekeeping they did behind the scenes.”

“No, Quorum, we need to move past depending on that.” Coming back had given Lodestar perspective that she’d lacked while living in the suburbs. While the guild had ultimately served the greater good in some ways, she didn’t like the way it was shaping their city. “The Alliance of Heroic Champions will be the ones to keep the people safe again. We’ll clean up the mess that one of our own helped make. No more depending on villains to police themselves. It’s time to stop being backseat leaders and take charge of things once more.”

“Couldn’t have said it better myself,” Professor Quantum agreed. “Nice to have you back—all the way back, Lodestar. And on that matter, I

have another boat coming in a few months' time, one that contains some experiments that should be of great help in reestablishing order. Until then, we need to sort out who our best people are and put them to work. Right now, the world has a lot of distrust for the AHC, and having our capes out keeping them safe is the only way to rebuild that trust."

"Apollo kept detailed records of everyone's strengths, weaknesses, and best role when put into a team," Quorum said. "He also has assessments for all of the new recruits we got from that last confluence. Some have already debuted, and others were getting prepped for it. We can have a wave of fresh faces on the street in a week or so if we push it."

Professor Quantum frowned. "I've heard about the hand he took with training our fresh capes. For him to be so involved with them, it might be prudent to assume their loyalty lies with him, not the organization. Perhaps it would be more prudent to simply cast them out before they have the chance to do more damage."

"Forget it," Lodestar said, her white light growing a touch brighter. "First off, Apollo has been the head trainer here for over three years, so you'll need to expel a lot of people if you don't want capes he taught. Secondly, I saw some of those rookies in action myself, and they've got their hearts in the right places. Plus enough power to back it up. Or are you just sore that one of the new teams managed to make it past all your defenses and break through your dome?"

"I will remind you that the system was in testing mode, which greatly reduced the power of the offensive countermeasures," Professor Quantum snapped. After a moment, he composed himself and continued. "But getting that far is still no small feat, especially for rookies. I find myself fighting disbelief at the idea that one of them could actually rip a hole in my barrier. I'll need to study this 'Cyber Geek' more closely. In fact, I believe I have a new device for him, one requisitioned some weeks ago."

"I'm impressed you didn't put it off longer," Lodestar said.

"My equipment duties take second place to my research, but I do get around to them eventually," Professor Quantum informed her. "At any rate, I suppose you're right about the breadth of Apollo's influence. The new recruits can stay, but I'm going to have them under close supervision. Any

hint of sharing their teacher's turncoat nature and they'll be lucky to only get kicked out from the AHC."

"That's as fair as we're going to get with this situation," Quorum said.

"Agreed," Lodestar added.

"Very well then, next topic." Professor Quantum flipped the page again, bringing up a whole new sheet of names and numbers. "It looks like all of our people have finally been accounted for. We lost many, mostly our untrained rookies on crowd control, but some were only injured. The pieces of Erinite were found in a neat stack outside the front door yesterday, so he's being taken to space to heal. Stalwart Iron is more problematic, as his core remains intact but the majority of his body was destroyed. A new body will need to be fashioned from the ground up before he can serve again, which presumably will fall on me to create. The rest are in respective healing bays and surgeries, and prognosis for all those still alive looks good. That reminds me: Quorum, book me a surgery room for this afternoon."

Lodestar raised an eyebrow in confusion. "You're going to pitch in on stitching people back together?"

"Obviously not; we have people for that. I just wanted to get Cyber Geek's upgrade installed as soon as possible, as it will also give me the chance to examine the power that bested my protective dome," Professor Quantum explained.

"I thought he just pulled digital items from a computer," Lodestar said.

"Exactly," Professor Quantum agreed. "But he's been using a wrist model, much too cumbersome and limited. I have a far better idea, one that will be portable, accessible, and greatly increase the variety of items he can wield. Plus, by my calculations, there's only a twenty-two percent chance that the surgery will blind him."

Lodestar made a mental note to chat with Cyber Geek and make sure he knew exactly what risks the "upgrade" would entail. Professor Quantum was brilliant, no one could dispute that, but he'd also always been

a lot better at relating to numbers than to people, which could be a bit off-putting, if not dangerous.

Then again, Apollo had been great with people, and look where that got them. Maybe numbers weren't so bad, after all.

\* \* \*

Tori stood in the afternoon sun, watching as crews sorted through the remains of Ivan's home. Behind her, a moving company was packing the last of what they'd been able to salvage into a giant truck, one that would soon head to a lovely townhome rented under a perfectly legal comprehensive care package provided by Vendallia for personal emergencies. She had to tip her hat to Doctor Mechanicall—putting guild members into normal, boring jobs with actual insurance was a much easier way to help them out when things got crazy.

As a conversation with the foreman wrapped up, Ivan walked over and stood beside Tori, listening as the crews debated how to go about fixing a house that had walls punched through and a giant energy beam fire from the center. It hadn't collapsed completely, but Tori had done enough structural damage that they may just have to tear it down and rebuild from the ground up.

"What did you end up telling the neighbors, anyway?" Tori asked. She could see them peeking out from behind their curtains. A few had brought Ivan pies and baked goods while expressing their condolences. None of it seemed like the actions of a street that'd just found out a resident was a legendary villain.

"That the men who tried to rob Vendallia turned out to be part of an organized gang. They wanted a combination of revenge and to finish the job, which hatched a plan that centered on kidnapping me. One of them was lying in wait for me to come home, but a rival gang tracked them down and ended up slugging it out on my front lawn."

"And all the wards that Rust Tooth cut through?"

"No idea." Ivan gave a shrug. "Must have been set by the crazy criminal in the metal armor, probably to keep me from calling for help. This

is all just what the AHC told me in the after-report, anyway. Only so many details provided.”

“Well, they seem to have bought it, and that’s all that matters.” Tori looked around the peaceful neighborhood, remembering how dull it had seemed when she was first driven in. “I’d hate for you to lose this place.”

“That might be inevitable,” Ivan said. “With the guild exposed and Fornax publicly seen alive, it might be too risky to keep living in an area like this. When Doc finishes the new headquarters, I might take him up on a residency there.” Neither he nor Tori worried about discussing these matters so close to the workers. Everyone, from the movers to the construction crew, was in Wade’s employ. Tori suspected some of them might be mechanical, but hadn’t been able to get a good enough look to be sure.

“Don’t live in the guild. You’d hate it there,” Tori told him. “Keep being Ivan. That’s what makes you really happy. And besides, how would your kids visit a room in the guild?”

“I’d probably keep the townhouse for appearances, but as I said, this is all conjecture. Right now, there’s no headquarters to live in; the whole place was purged as soon as everyone left the building. As for visitation... Janet is less than thrilled that my past brought Rick and Beth into harm’s way. Somehow she’s even blaming me for Beth’s powers.”

“Did you ever figure out when those happened?” Tori asked. Evidently, Beth’s abilities had manifested only two weeks prior, well past the last confluence. But confluences were just events that spiked the meta-human population; there were plenty that came into being between confluences.

“Not yet, but we will,” Ivan said. “Beth and I, and Janet, had a long talk. She’s going to be getting the help she needs to control her abilities. Although my ex-wife isn’t keen on the idea, even she can see that Beth having blades in her body that she can’t control is too dangerous for everyone, especially Beth.”

“Is she... I mean, will Beth be joining the guild?” Tori shuffled uncomfortably, picturing the sweet girl she’d met having to pass the trials or



be put in the ground. Worse, she imagined the poor bastard who actually tried to see that threat through and had to go through Ivan to do it.

“God no. I love my daughter too much to ever let her be a part of all... this.” Ivan gestured to the wrecked house, torn apart by a member of the very guild that he was supposed to be able to trust. “She’ll be working with some old, non-guild friends. People I trust.”

“That seems like a better fit,” Tori agreed.

“What about you, though? I heard they were able to get a lot of your lab out last night, but I doubt there’s room for it at the hotel.” Ivan and Tori had both been put up in rooms at a local mid-range hotel while their living situation was worked out, along with dozens of other displaced Ridge City residents.

“It’s in private storage for now,” Tori said. “I actually just came to grab a few tools I forgot, and then I’m off to meet Beverly. She’s been poring through real estate ads, as well as talking with the council, and she says she’s got a few leads on places that will fit our extra needs.”

“Pick something affordable,” Ivan cautioned. “With the guild as it is now, there’s not going to be any easy jobs for a while.”

“Evidently, Beverly negotiated a bit of a stipend from Arcanicus, and we’ve still got our heist money. And I do get a paycheck, you know. Or I will, once Vendallia reopens.” Every business in the downtown area was closed for at least the next week as they waited for cleanup crews to clear the streets of debris. The AHC had capes helping around the clock, though people weren’t always happy to see them.

“Well then, I guess I’ll still see you around the office,” Ivan said.

“Damn right! Didn’t think you were getting rid of me that easy, did you?”

“When I heard you’d been attacked, I confess there were some worried moments there.” Ivan glanced at her then looked at the remains of his house. “I see now how truly foolish that was.”

“What can I say? I’m kind of a badass.” Tori slung her backpack, filled with tools to patch up the remains of her busted meta-suit, over her shoulder. “Though, I admit, having a good teacher helped.”

“And you weren’t the worst student I ever trained,” Ivan said.

“But I did set one hell of a high bar for whoever comes next.” Tori took a few steps away and threw a leg around the used motorcycle she’d picked up on the cheap. It needed a lot of work, but that would have to wait until she actually had a garage or driveway again. Hopefully Beverly was on the ball. “I’ll see you next week at the office, Ivan.”

“Try not to be late,” he called as she slipped her dark helmet over her head.

Tori merely waved, a noncommittal gesture that she certainly felt didn’t constitute a pledge of promptness, then gunned the engine and drove out of the driveway, past the staring neighbors peering from their windows.

\* \* \*

Donald felt like he’d gone ten rounds with the Trolls of Elgthok. He had been in his bed all day, leveling up a new character in *Legacy World* and trying not to wince every time he moved his shoulder. Evidently the suit from *Blaster Brahs* absorbed a lot of the lethal damage with its shields, but the small-scale knock-around stuff still got through. While an hour or so in the healing tanks would have left him good as new, Donald didn’t bother trying to requisition one. For one thing, they were all occupied, filled with people who’d taken far more serious damage than he had. More importantly, Donald had seen some of the injuries capes came back with. He’d be damned if he was going to complain about something as mundane as soreness.

Even his own team had taken more damage than he’d realized. Hat Trick had been limping along with almost half the muscle fiber in her leg burned away; if the beams hadn’t cauterized as they burned, she likely would have bled out on the street. It was only thanks to Professor Quantum’s return that they’d been able to fully heal her leg instead of giving her a mechanical replacement. Medley had taken enough damage to kill a normal person five times over, and only his rapid healing and thick

hide had kept him alive. Apparently, both factors were still getting stronger as the mutation in his body evolved to keep pace with the trials he was enduring. Cold Shoulder had actually collapsed from exhaustion once they got through the door; she'd pushed herself so hard and used her powers so much that her body had nothing left to give.

And Donald, the one who'd been acting as their leader, had walked away with only scrapes and bruises. The guilt churned his stomach. Why had he made it through relatively unscathed? He wasn't stronger than them, or better, or probably even smarter. No, he'd made it because they were taking the bigger blows to protect him. Protect the gun that could punch a hole in the barrier, really. His team had beaten themselves to hell to keep him safe, and now Donald could barely stand to look at himself in the mirror.

That was why he'd agreed to Professor Quantum's upgrade, even as Lodestar gently explained all the risks that came with it. If it could make him stronger, he was on board. Donald didn't want to come back from another mission with his team, his friends, barely surviving. He didn't want them to be the ones protecting him. He wanted to be able to protect himself, and the people around him.

Right now, Cyber Geek was just a guy with a weird ability. If Donald ever wanted to push himself to be a true hero, then it would mean sacrifice and risk. Getting the upgrade was just one part of it. He'd officially sent an e-mail to Vendallia accepting their offer for early retirement. It was time to stop living with one foot in both worlds. If he wanted to be like Lodestar, to be a real superhero who could make a difference in the world, then he would commit to it wholeheartedly.

Nearby, his phone vibrated. With a glance, he saw it was a text from Tori. She'd completely understood why he'd had to blow off coffee; in fact, she'd been taking shelter when the attacks happened anyway. Part of him wanted to rebook their meeting so badly, but not yet. Not until he'd made real progress, gotten a plan in order. Until then, he had to focus, prioritize training over his crush.

It was time to start seriously leveling up Cyber Geek. That was the only way Donald could look his injured team in the eyes again.

\* \* \*

“Current estimates show we can have one of the backup headquarters functional in five weeks, fully operational in ten,” Xelas said.

Wade nodded thoughtfully. This was not a meeting, per se, in that none of the other councilors were present. It was more like a summary of the actions before them, conducted by the two people who would actually have to put in much of the work to see things done. While Wade appreciated the need for the rest of the council in large decisions, the minutiae of rebuilding was better left to swift decision-makers rather than a committee.

“Let’s go for the ten. Might as well welcome everyone back to a proper home,” Wade said. “Speaking of, where are we on tracking everyone down?”

“Almost everyone has checked in after they scattered, as per protocol.” Xelas skimmed her mental memory banks, seeing who was still unaccounted for. “We’re missing a few of the ones that have been confirmed as traitors and some with allegiances unknown. Want me to get people hunting?”

“No, let’s wait a little longer.” Wade drummed his fingers on the back of the couch, staring out at the city from his luxury penthouse perched high in the sky. An array of papers was spread out on the coffee table before him, only a fraction of the paperwork and issues currently facing him. It was why he’d been stuck in the office for days, having to rely on Xelas as his eyes and ears. She sat in a nearby chair, unfettered by anything as mundane as pages cluttering her immediate area. Wade technically had the digital option as well, but he’d long ago found that having something tactile to sort through helped him think.

“Some might need more time to get safe and check in, and for those who never do, we can offer hunting them as jobs when the guild reopens its doors. There are several members I prefer to have occupied whenever possible, and that’s a task which is unlikely to raise any AHC alarms. Speaking of traitors, how’s the magic division adjusting to their new councilor?”

“The division is fine,” Xelas said. “Arcanicus damn near founded that division, so everyone is good having him lead. He, on the other hand, keeps nagging me about finding a new councilor, saying he’s too old for the job. I can bully him along for a while longer, but it’s not a permanent solution.”

“None of the options before us are,” Wade replied. “Tell him it’s just until the guild is running properly again and we can have a proper election. After that, we’ll coerce him into keeping the job by other means, but it should buy us a couple of months. By the time he really wants to quit, hopefully a successor will have revealed themselves. Moving on, have our incarcerated guild members been freed?”

“There was a lot of hemming and hawing along with more than a few tails and wiretaps after they left, but yes, the AHC has been forced to drop all charges on the ones they captured.” Xelas tapped her fingers together, replaying the press conferences in her head at lightning speeds. “They weren’t happy about it, though. We should probably keep a low profile, at least for a while.”

“That won’t be a problem.” Wade rose from his couch and walked to the window, peering out at the evening sun shining over Ridge City. “With no guild, our people will keep their heads down on their own. Even once we’re reformed, I plan to stay off the AHC’s radar. It occurred to me that perhaps we’ve been doing our civic duty a bit too freely, keeping the worst of the scum off the streets and letting them snatch up the easy pickings. Now that the AHC has been publicly weakened and the shadowy guild of rumor publicly exposed, I have a feeling we’ll see a big upturn in meta-human crime, and that’s not including all the criminals who escaped from Rookstone. Sooner or later, they’ll realize that having one spider in the house kills a lot of the lesser insects.”

“You want to wait until they ask us to work?” Xelas said.

“Ask? No, nothing that easy.” Wade turned from the window and walked back to his couch, picking up a pile of papers. “I want them to beg for us to take up arms again. Until then, we focus on only doing smart jobs and keeping ourselves safe. Without a guild to keep peace in the underworld, this planet is about to get a lot more dangerous.”

\* \* \*

The force of nature that was Penelope slammed into Ivan's legs. She wrapped him in a small hug even as her yell of "Uncle Ivan!" was muffled by the fabric of his pants around the knees.

Ivan smiled and gave her a few small pats before turning his attention to Helen, who stood a few feet back. She was lovely, of course, though personally, Ivan preferred it when she was further aged into womanhood. Even without the glow of Lodestar, she was still nineteen again, no older than the day she was struck. It would be her age forever, or at least until she managed to completely stop calling on her power.

"Glad to see you as you," she said, giving him a strong hug. While they hadn't met on the battlefield, she'd no doubt seen the news and read the reports of what he'd done while out of control. Deep down, part of Ivan had expected her to be waiting as Lodestar, ready to ambush him and drag him back to Rookstone.

"Glad to be me," Ivan replied. He finally extricated himself from Penelope and Helen, and then reached into his back pocket. "And that reminds me, I brought gifts. One for you, Penelope, and a matching one for your mommy." Ivan plunked a small necklace into Penelope's hands, enjoying the sight as her eyes grew wide with wonder before handing a larger version to Helen.

"Thank you, Uncle Ivan!"

"Why don't you go try it on in the bathroom, and then you can come show us how you look?" Helen suggested. The words were barely out of her mouth before Penelope was off like a shot, moving at the speed only metas and children could manage. With her daughter gone, Helen's face turned skeptical as she looked at Ivan. "Spill it, what are these?"

"Hers is a shielding charm that Arcanicus whipped up," Ivan said. "It will give her some protection if she's attacked and set off a beacon if she's put in real danger. I had him key it carefully to make sure some kid pushing her down on the swings wouldn't set it off, so it reacts to the attacker's power and intention. Also comes with a minor compulsion

enchantment to make sure she always wants to wear it. My kids got similar presents yesterday.”

“And is mine a shield, too?” Helen chuckled at that; the mere idea of her needing protection magic was beyond laughable. So far as anyone knew, while Lodestar could be beaten, even knocked out, nothing had ever managed to permanently kill her.

“No, we know how magic works around you. Yours is just a piece of jewelry.” Ivan pulled another object from his pockets, a dark case that he handed over to Helen. “These, however, are something special.”

Helen accepted the case and gently pushed it open, revealing a pair of thickly-rimmed glasses. “Oh my, these take me back. I haven’t worn a pair of glasses since the early days, when I was still worried about people connecting me with the glowing woman in the sky. Were you feeling nostalgic?” “A touch,” Ivan admitted, “but that pair is something Wade whipped up special. If you’d be willing to humor me for just a moment, please try them on.”

Helen looked a bit uncertain as she pulled the glasses from the case and slipped them onto her face. There was no distortion around her eyes, as the lenses were there purely for show. No part of Lodestar, or the woman who hosted her power, was weak or lacking. Once she was done getting the glasses into place, Ivan continued the explanation.

“Feel the small indentation on right side near the lens? Press it down for three seconds.”

Helen complied, and at the end of the third second, a shimmer surrounded her. When it cleared, he was once more staring at the Helen he’d known for the past few years, aged past that fateful day when she was nineteen years old. She caught sight of herself in the mirror and gasped, then whirled around to face Ivan.

“This is too much. A miniature holographic projector like this probably cost in the millions.”

“Only if you pay retail and don’t have a friend who spent a few weeks making the technology more cost-efficient,” he assured her. “And

what use would giving it back serve? Do you think there's someone else who wants to look like you?" Ivan quickly realized how that sounded, and began to hurriedly backpedal. "I mean, certainly countless women would like to look like you, but would you want them to? Not that we're mass-producing these or—"

"It's fine, Ivan, I got the gist of what you were going for," Helen said. "But I'm not sure I should accept this. I had a long talk with Penelope the night after the battle, and I'm not going to hide who I am from her anymore. She knows the truth now, and she'll grow up with the mother she actually has rather than who I wanted to be." She started to take the glasses off, but Ivan stopped her.

"I'm not telling you to wear them around Penelope, or when to wear them all. But the illusion might come in handy if you want to take a normal job again, or meet with her teachers, or do anything that revolves around not always looking nineteen. That's why there's an on/off switch. There's also a dial on the bottom that will move your age up and down. It's just a tool, one to help you have a small piece of the normal life you lost."

"Thank you, Ivan." Helen adjusted the glasses slightly then pressed the button again until the illusion vanished. "You know you don't owe me this, though, don't you? What happened wasn't your fault. Sooner or later, I was always going to have to come back."

"But if I hadn't lost control, it might not have been so soon," Ivan whispered, turning his face from hers.

"None of that, now. What you thought happened... I don't know that I'd have behaved any better, and I don't have that thing inside me. The AHC isn't even trying to press charges for the murder of Blunderbuss. You were a victim of Apollo and Balaam, just like the rest of the city." Helen gently took his face in her hands and turned it so that they were looking into each other's eyes. "I wouldn't lie to you about this. If I thought you were responsible, you know I'd have to bring you in. Trust me, Ivan. Trust my judgment and my actions. Don't let this eat you up inside."

"Even if I wanted to, I don't have the luxury," Ivan said. "Too many people counting on me, a meta-daughter not the least among them. That's



what the necklaces and glasses are, officially anyway. Thank you gifts for agreeing to teach Beth.”

“Then you really shouldn’t have. Even if you hadn’t done so much for us, I’d still consider it a pleasure,” Helen said. “Truthfully, it’s gotten me thinking that maybe the AHC needs to offer a more detached training system, something for meta-humans that want to get control but don’t necessarily want to be superheroes. Especially for younger people. Something funded and helped by the AHC but remaining legally unaffiliated, so that no one would need to worry about getting recruited.”

“Hey now, keep thinking like that and you’re going to dry up all the recruits from our pool,” Ivan told her.

Helen’s face turned serious, and she glanced down the hall to make certain Penelope hadn’t returned yet. “I know you’re kidding, but you need to understand that things have changed. You all got away with a lot of stuff while Professor Quantum and I were on our sabbaticals, but all that came to an end three days ago. Your internal revolution spilled onto the streets, and while I’ll own that some of ours helped cause it, that means we have to fix our system as well as yours.”

“With Lodestar back, I’m sure we’ll be needed less,” Ivan replied. “But don’t expect us to suddenly stop existing. If anything, what happened proved the need for our organization. You saw what happens when meta-criminals aren’t properly disciplined and the upstarts aren’t quelled. There’s a meta ecosystem, and we play a part in it whether the AHC likes it or not.”

The sound of Penelope’s feet racing back down the hall forced them to pull apart, only now realizing how close they’d allowed themselves to stand.

“I can’t protect you, Ivan. Not from the law. If you all slip out of line, you’ll be on your own.”

“That’s perfectly all right. We can protect ourselves,” Ivan assured her. “So if the AHC decides to make a real move, tell them to bring the best they’ve got. Wade has already prepared a slew of slander and harassment lawsuits based on what we endured this time around. The law cuts both ways.”

“Why do I put up with you again?”

“Because once two people have beaten the living hell out of one another then helped save the world together, there’s a bit of a bond there.” Ivan got in the last words as Penelope came rocketing around the corner, showing off her new piece of jewelry that she’d finally managed to get fastened around her neck.

Even if she hadn’t appeared, neither would have said the real reason they put up with one another. Some words were just too dangerous to speak, for the ones uttering them as much as the ones listening.

\* \* \*

“What do you think?” Beverly spread her arms out, gesturing to the open-concept living room housed by brick walls and the kitchen that was almost as big as Ivan’s. From her vantage point in the doorway, Tori could already see into one of the bedrooms, which did look sizable and had more brick walls inside. It had taken several hours to get an appointment with the property manager, and Tori was half-convinced that Beverly had ended up employing threats, so she’d been expecting something amazing. This was... less than opulent.

“Well, I like the location; we’re in the heart of what’s left of downtown, so that will be cool when it’s fixed up,” Tori said, trying to be positive. “But it’s the fourth floor in a walk-up, which is going to get really old when we’re lugging in groceries. The warehouse decor isn’t bad... little more modern than I like, but I can deal. My main problem is that it’s really pricey, and even with a third bedroom to use as a lab, splitting the rent two ways might get taxing.”

“Oh, that third bedroom isn’t for you,” Beverly said. “But you do have a lab. This place has personal underground parking garages: surrounded by concrete, inaccessible except through the building, and up to spec for retrofitting with lab equipment. I ran it by the council, and they’re willing to purchase and renovate three of them to give you the space you need as part of our home-loss compensation.”

“That’s... actually a perfect fit for what I need.” She looked at the apartment with fresh eyes, imagining being able to escape to a new

subterranean lair at the end of each day. Bonus: if the guild was paying for it, that meant they could have more cash for rent. But there was still no sense in spending money they didn't have to. "Are there no two-bedrooms we can see for a cheaper rate?"

"Not many. This place took some damage, so space is limited," Beverly explained. "Besides, I thought maybe we could put someone else in the third bedroom. Split rent and bills three ways, if you're into it."

"Who?"

"Chloe. Her place got pretty much torched in the fire. She's been crashing with some friends, but it doesn't sound comfortable. I mentioned I was apartment-hunting for us, so she asked me to keep an eye out for any studios that might be in her price range," Beverly said. "This seemed like a better option all around."

"Is she okay with our... affiliation?" Tori knew that Chloe was now informed about their membership in a guild of villains and that she'd evidently had taken the news well, but there was a big jump between acceptance and wanting to bunk with confirmed criminals.

"I floated the idea past her, no promises made, and she seemed excited about it." Beverly walked over to the living area, looking out to see the bustling streets below them. "We can find another place if you want. It's just that I've always lived with a lot of family nearby. Moving to the guild was scary, but there were always others around. I thought it might be nice to have three of us starting out together, sort of a support net in case we need it."

Tori ducked into the nearest bedroom, checking out the size and closet space before noting the private bathroom. The next room was roughly the same, as was the next. Though their shapes were a bit different, the sizes seemed consistent. Well, that was one fight they didn't need to have, at least.

"A private attached bathroom for every occupant. That's pretty swanky," Tori said. "It looks like you put a lot of thought into this place, and they have a lab, so why the hell not? If nothing else, I know Chloe can

make a good pot of coffee every morning. Just one thing, though, what's the policy on renovations?"

"I thought you might ask that, so I checked," Beverly said. "Upgrades are fine, as long as you don't knock out any walls."

"So much for the indoor tennis court, but I think I can make it work." Tori wrapped her arm around Beverly's shoulders and steered her toward the door. "Come on, let's go try and terrify a property manager into giving us cheaper rent before we sign the lease."

"See, this is why you need roommates," Beverly said as they stepped through the door. "There's nothing like teamwork for properly instilling fear in someone's heart."

\* \* \*

Nexus stood on the roof of the building where Beverly and Tori were currently heading down the stairs. His attention was not on them but on the bustle of people moving through the streets of downtown: some cleaning, some commuting, some taking pictures for their online lives. It was a curious sight, which was why he bothered showing up for it.

This was not the first world where Fornax was stopped, the riots halted, and Balaam punished. But it had sustained far less damage than almost any other in the process. The AHC still stood, the guild was more than a cemetery, and Ridge City wasn't razed to the ground. Many universes were reeling by this point, destined for years of struggle before any sense of peace reasserted itself. Of course, in the realities that did find their way onto this path, it wasn't like the show was over.

Quite the contrary, really. Like here, the tension simmered beneath the surface. Instead of an all-out war, these tended to have smaller skirmishes, at least until the tension reached its breaking point. *Then* things got interesting. Nexus was quite pleased that this, one of his favorite dimensions, had happened upon the more interesting course of events. If it had ended in the more common way, there would have been a great spectacle and then lots of boredom. This way, he was going to be treated to a much more fascinating turn of events, one he'd possibly never seen before. It would take time, but things were going to get very interesting

again. Soon, the old grudges and locked away secrets would come rising to the surface, and when they did, he'd have an excellent vantage point to watch from.

All he had to do was be patient. And perhaps cause a little mischief of his own when the occasion demanded. After all, the most fun part of all shows was being allowed a little participation from time to time.

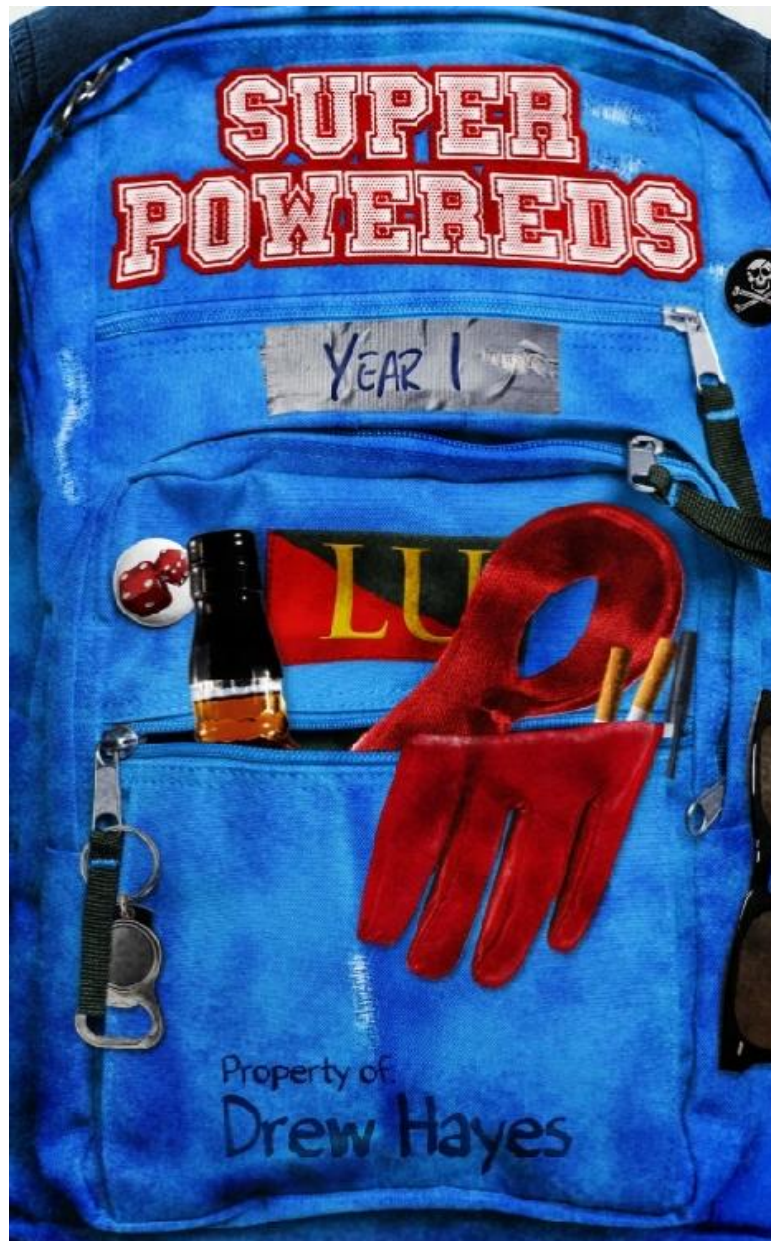
But for now, the world was boring, and there were other universes to watch. One of which was especially entertaining. Three of him were already there but more would soon join. That little gem was too special to miss even the smallest bit of, one of those rarest of instances that required careful observation.

In a far-off world, history had been made. For the first time in all of the multiverse, someone had successfully killed a Lodestar.

**End of Book 1**

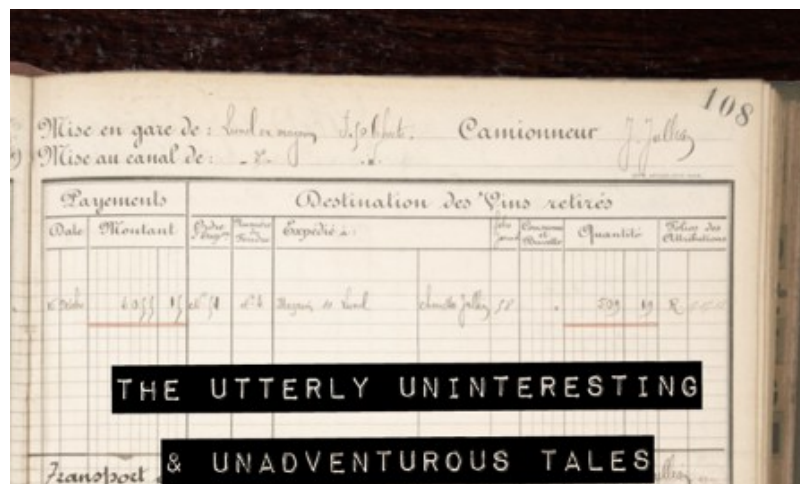
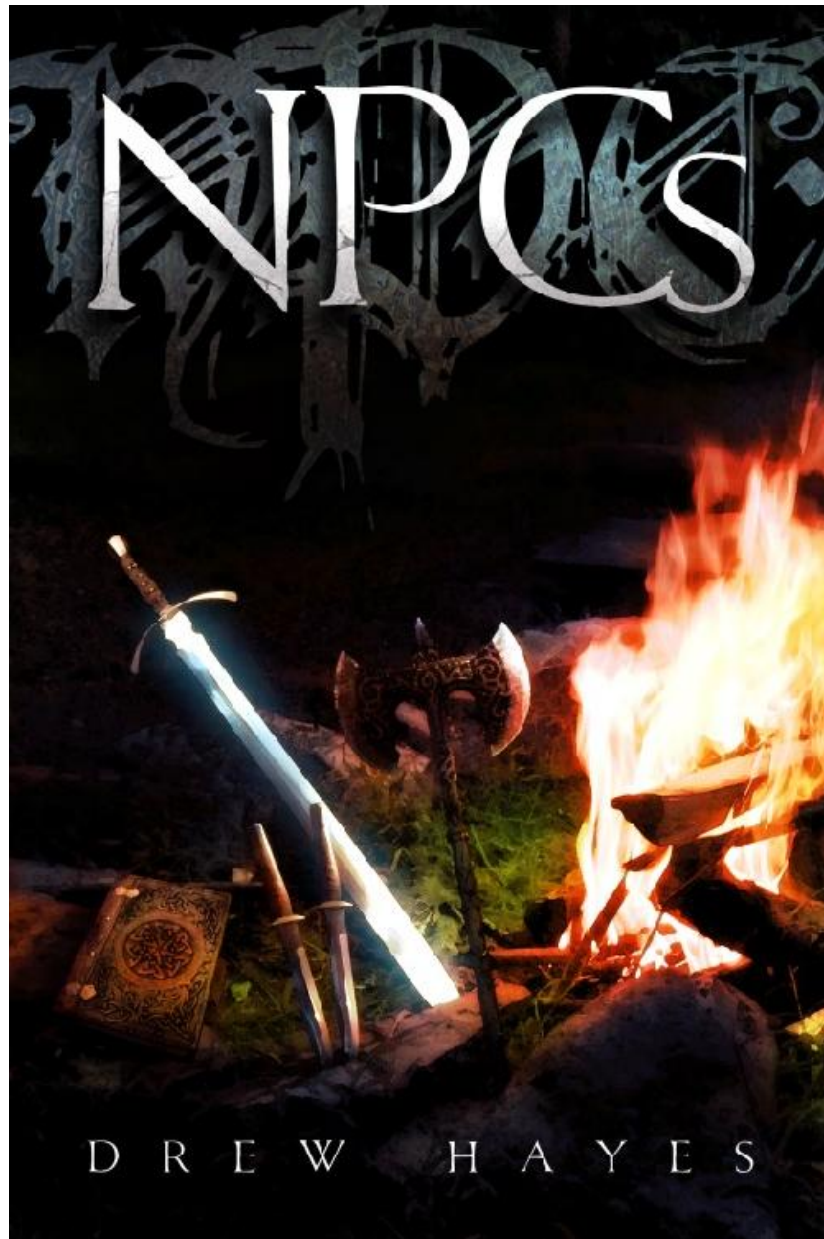
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## **Other Novels by Drew Hayes**











## About the Author



Drew Hayes is an author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term

"employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

Read or purchase more of his work at his site: [DrewHayesNovels.com](http://DrewHayesNovels.com)

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# VILLAINS' VIGNETTES VOLUME

DREW HAYES



# VILLAINS' VIGNETTES

VOLUME I

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## AUTHOR'S NOTE ON CONTEXT AND TIMING

Hey there my awesome readers! The stories you're about to see occur within the *Villains' Code* universe, mostly after the events of the second book, *Bones of the Past*. While I've tried to supply enough context so they can be enjoyed without prior reading, I'd recommend checking the novels out if you enjoy these shorter tales.

If you're already familiar with the *Villains' Code* world and wondering if these stories will tie into the main series, the answer there is a *resounding* yes. The following novellas will have aspects that connect directly to both the next novel, as well as the series overall.

That's all the extra context needed, so I won't hold you up any longer; save to say thanks for picking up my work, and I hope you enjoy *Villains' Vignettes: Volume I*.

Happy reading!

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# A NIGHT IN HALLOWVILLE

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I

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## SEPTEMBER 30TH - FOUR MINUTES TO MIDNIGHT

Caderville was a small town of little note, unless one were to ask its residents, of course. They would be happy to tell any inquirers about the many matters of great import occurring within its borders. From the local cattle breeder's aspiration of heading to the state fair to the rumors that their postmaster had a cousin who was *meta*, of all things, there was certainly adequate excitement in Caderville for many of the people who chose it as their home.

However, it was still a small town in rural Idaho and had no activity occurring at such a late hour. The bells of the local church wouldn't ring until morning, and only on a Sunday at that. Their lone gas station had long ago shut down for the night, posting a sign advising any who stopped that the next spot was another ten miles on. Not that anyone used these roads at such times. Still, it was seen as polite to leave a notice.

As the minutes ticked down on the silent, unmoving streets, a shadow shifted slightly. It bent and turned, taking on a human-esque appearance as its neck craned to better survey Caderville in all its glory. Across the city, a dozen more shadows did the same, exploring it from every nook and cranny.

When the midnight hour arrived, unmarked by any grandeur or notice, the original shadow released a single word from its insubstantial lips.

"Perfection."

Like a sinking island amidst a sea of shade, Caderville was suddenly swallowed up as animated darkness surged from the ground. It rose past the close-cut lawns and decorative mailboxes, higher than the carefully pruned

trees and brick chimney stacks. Up and up, until the wave of rising darkness appeared to kiss the heavens themselves. Then, like an umbral rain, it fell.

What was revealed could no longer be seen as Caderville, yet its origins were equally undeniable. Was that not Farmer Jake's pasture, where the glowing-eyed scarecrows prowled through the waving cornstalks? Could one not see the similarities between the visibly booby-trapped brutalist building and the town's school? A great ringing from the bells of what had once been Caderville's church echoed through the night, awakening its residents to the changes wrought to their town—and themselves.

Through it all, one figure stood smiling from ear to ear. Where the first shadow had appeared now lingered a pale woman in what began as an elegant gown, before morphing to a capricious and billowing skirt. She was wrapped in a thick cloak, though the hood lay on her back, revealing dark hair which fell just low enough to graze her own neck. Across the entire ensemble, the coloration of black and orange held utter and unquestioned dominance.

She could feel the panic budding and building all throughout the town. Normally, it was a flavor she savored dearly; however, that was a tribulation meant for guests. These would be her staff, and as such, it was vital they maintain a calm, collected perspective.

The awakening of her power had only begun, and she was still a month from its zenith, but she needed barely more than a thought to reach out and touch the minds of those within her domain. Along with her words, she sent a sensation of trust and ease. Everything would be all right. *They* were the fortunate ones.

For the next month, each would be entirely protected by her power. They would be without pain, without fear, without need or suffering. And when her time was done, she would impart a boon to each, balancing the debt for services rendered. They were safe.

It was the *guests* who would have to face danger.



“Spooky Trudy is back.”

When Helen had asked what the heck was so gosh-darned important as to require waking her up at this late hour, she was expecting a quick

response about some sort of giant monster approaching a populated area. In other words, an easy problem with a quick fix.

If the Queen of Halloween had appeared again, Helen could feel the next four weeks of her life turning into a mad scramble already. “Do we have any experienced staff to start a perimeter? Her last time around here was what... nine years ago?”

There was a slight, awkward pause before Quorum responded. “Three, actually. She appeared once during your sabbatical, but there was no reason to bother you.”

She’d missed a Spooky Trudy appearance? Just how out of the loop had Helen been? There were usually news items about that one, though her time for such viewings had been limited back then. Even for superheroes, single-parenting a toddler could be a demanding endeavor.

“More recent is good. Hopefully, we’ve got enough staff to get things set up right without someone trying to go overboard. Still, we’ve got to really drive it home to anyone who gets put on rotation out there: do not block access under any circumstances. We’re there to educate and support only. If people choose to go in after knowing what it is they’re doing, that’s their decision to make.”

“And the ones who inevitably want to enter themselves?” Quorum asked.

There *would* be entrants among their own numbers; Helen knew that all too well. The treats offered weren’t easily ignored, and as members of the Alliance of Heroic Champions, the largest superhero organization on the planet, they would have high opinions of their own chances. What awaited many would hopefully be a sound lesson on the importance of understanding limitations, but sadly, the stakes often went much higher when playing Spooky Trudy’s game.

“Tell them about the rules we’ve figured out, prepare them for the possibility of failure, and make *sure* they understand the difference between day and night. Other than that, we’re bound by the same rules as with anyone else: we can’t refuse entry. Aside from her own after-dark age restriction, anyone who makes it there and wants to enter, gets to.”

Spooky Trudy was an organized kind of chaos, usually. She took over a town at the start of October and held it until the last stroke of midnight on Halloween. Within that domain, the holiday was made manifest and served as a testing ground for those who dared enter. When the time passed, the

town would be returned to normal, every resident whole, healthy, and better off in some form or fashion than they'd been before.

Unless entry was denied. When that occurred, Spooky Trudy's power reached out, gripping hold of the overreaching interloper. Helen had seen the results of such offense and was in no hurry to ever repeat that experience.

Wrapping up her call after getting a few more details, Helen set the phone aside and looked longingly at her pillow before stifling a yawn. When it finally passed, she headed for her closet, where her Lodestar suit would be waiting.

It was going to be one heck of a busy October.

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## OCTOBER 19TH – EARLY AFTERNOON

“We’re here!” Chloe announced, causing Tori, in the back seat, to finally look up from her notebook. Stifling a yawn, she glanced out at the array of hastily erected roadside stands lining either side of the rented sedan, each hawking all manner of Halloween merchandise. There were pails for hauling candy, flashlights for navigating dark areas, and an unexpected number of merchants selling what they advertised as “comfortable shoes”. All of them were dwarfed, however, by the sea of costume sellers.

One couldn’t look more than a few feet without seeing new costumes for sale. The most frequent finds were the outfits of famous capes; ample Quorum and Professor Quantum outfits were on display, though they couldn’t touch the number of Lodestar knockoffs being sold. Looking it over, Tori felt her suspicions rise.

“I call bullshit,” she announced. “Magic town or not, there’s no way people get the power of Lodestar in there. There wouldn’t be a town *left*.”

“So, we can safely assume Tori didn’t visit the FAQ website you emailed us,” Beverly noted to Chloe before turning around from her spot in the passenger seat to face her friend. “You’re part right, part wrong. The town gives an echo of a costume’s associated powers. Many theorize that it’s based on how we all perceive the abilities to work rather than on their real structure.”

Chloe jumped in too, visibly eager to show off her knowledge. “Lodestar is a really popular choice, though. You get flight, super-strength, enhanced speed—all the classics. Just not at her level.”

“Thank heavens for that.” Tori barely repressed a shudder at the notion. Helen, the person who wore the mantle of Lodestar, was an incredibly fair-minded, responsible, and empathetic being. Tori was still scared shitless of how much power that woman had at her fingertips. She didn’t dare imagine some random schmuck with that kind of might. “Guess there’s probably a good few Fornaxs, as well.”

Chloe flinched at the name, paling slightly. Although she knew Beverly and Tori were members of a guild of super-villains, she hadn’t been enlightened on specific details... such as who Tori’s mentor was. Since Beverly did know, she was more prepared for the query.

“There are a few who try it every year, but the process of trying to cross through as Fornax is reported to be... unpleasant at best. One account I read called it the most painful experience of his entire life.”

Of course. Even cosmic forces of magic played favorites.

A car honked at them to move faster, as if it couldn’t see the line of vehicles blocking their way forward, and Tori lifted a middle finger on reflex. Part of her was tempted to heat one of the tires until it burst, but that would screw the entire line of people behind them. While most of them were none of Tori’s concern, she *did* have some friends crammed into a van further back.

Not for the first time, she wondered how she’d gotten here. When news of Hallowville’s return broke, there wasn’t a single piece of Tori that was tempted. Sure, she knew the legends—that within its depths lay powerful treats that could change entire lives. Enchanted tools, secret knowledge, even permanent magical abilities—there was no telling what could be uncovered by venturing inside.

Except that it *would* be magical, rendering all of it effectively useless to Tori. Science and magic weren’t technically enemies, but they functioned on different foundations, and forcing them to interact was notoriously difficult. There was a reason her meta-suit never made use of enchanted metals or magic-fueled weapons, despite the advantage they might offer: the chances of catastrophic failure were simply too overwhelming.

But Chloe had been another matter. From the moment word came down, she was determined to go, even putting in for vacation time from her job at Ridge City Grinders. Knowing how much Chloe threw herself into work, that had been a clear indication that she was serious, so her roommates had elected to come along. Rumor made it clear that Hallowville wasn’t just a

town of opportunity; it also came with serious danger. Ones they weren't going to let a friend face by herself.

At least they'd be starting in the daytime, when Hallowville was safe. Despite what Beverly thought, Tori had done *some* reading up, when time allowed. Enough to know that Hallowville had two sides. During the daytime, it was essentially the family-friendly version of Halloween. Monsters were silly and sweet, candy was found freely, and people could play with their costume-powers as they liked.

After night fell, however, the town would change. The sweet pastiche would fall away, revealing the darker side of Halloween. Snapping claws and biting teeth, glowing eyes in the shadows, whispering voices from just out of sight—the danger became very, *very* real, but so did the prizes.

The throngs of people approaching Hallowville, standing now where the town of Caderville had once lived, knew that as well. While some came to play in the day, it served as a training ground for many more. Learning the layout, getting familiar with one's powers, preparing for nightfall—the more serious visitors used their daylight hours well.

Tori ignored them all, attention once more on her notebook, or rather, on the schematic she was fiddling with. Testing on the material for her new meta-armor had just about completed, with exceptional results. Since incorporating it would necessitate a rebuild, she'd seen the opportunity as a chance for a complete redesign, making her invention into a true second model.

All too soon, the car came to a halt and she tucked her notebook away. They'd arrived in a large parking lot that had once been someone's field. The owner was probably going to be pissed when the month was out, but that wasn't Tori's headache, so she paid it no mind.

"All right, everyone has their costume accessories?" Chloe asked. Her own outfit was part dress, part robes, all keyed to shades of cerulean and silver. Resting on her forehead was a painted-on third eye with a silver iris. While she wouldn't win any costume contests, she was certainly recognizable as Oralov, possibly one of the greatest seer-superheroes ever to have lived. She'd passed long before Tori's time, but there was no shortage of tales talking about Oralov's curious actions and the dire cataclysms she claimed they avoided.

Beverly had hidden her choice until arrival, keeping it cloaked under a large coat from the moment they left their hotel that morning until departing

the car. Shedding her coat revealed a very familiar costume, one Tori had seen endless variations of for the past mile of their drive.

“Really? You’re wearing a Lodestar costume.”

“We’re here to help keep Chloe safe. Not only is it one of the stronger options, it’s one we know a lot about,” Beverly defended. The outfit did suit her well, though Beverly took pains to make sure that that was true of everything she donned. “Don’t be salty at me because Ivan vetoed your idea.”

“He didn’t veto it. He just pointed out that dressing in a meta-suit while around a bunch of capes maybe wasn’t the *best* way to keep them from figuring certain things out.” Little interest as Tori had in Hallowville overall, the opportunity to gain insight into other powers was intriguing.

Her own mind lacked the legendary spark of meta-brilliance, being forced to muddle through on potent interest in a topic and ample hard work. This then, was a chance to see what such a power actually felt like, perhaps even get a few steps closer to it. Doctor Mechaniacal was her obvious first choice, as she not only held a deep respect for the man, but their fields of study overlapped on the topic of meta-suits.

After realizing Ivan’s point was valid, however, especially now that she’d stepped into the public eye with her product line, Tori was left with only two world-recognized geniuses to pick from. Tyranny was a strong option, except she wasn’t generally viewed in a favorable light outside of her own country’s borders and wearing her costume might draw the wrong kind of attention. Professor Quantum, on the other hand, was a piece of shit who’d personally fucked over Beverly’s family decades prior.

The choice had taken some time, but ultimately, knowing that they’d be around capes had pushed the issue. Tori had braced to abandon the idea entirely when she broached it with Beverly, but surprisingly, her roommate had been on board. Beverly’s words still rang in Tori’s mind as she donned the lensless square frames to complete her ensemble.

*“Fuck yes. Wear his costume. Steal his knowledge. Learn everything you can about that bastard. One day, I have a feeling we’re going to need it.”*

With a lab coat billowing behind her and a cheap charcoal suit with a red tie underneath, Tori had achieved a passable Professor Quantum costume.

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Part of Tori had wondered what the other group would dress as, but the one thing she hadn't anticipated was that their costumes would be... their costumes.

Standing near one of the several roads leading into Hallowville were the New Science Sentries. Once, that had been a four-person team, but with the loss of Presto, it now consisted of Tachyonic, Plasmodia, and Agent Quantum—or Kyle, Ellie, and Austin when not using official names. Upon seeing Tori, Beverly, and Chloe, Austin waved, then froze momentarily.

That wasn't totally unexpected—the man had a habit of getting a deer-in-the-headlights look around Beverly—but this time, he wasn't looking at the eye-catching woman in a Lodestar outfit. Austin's face was locked on Tori, and she didn't expect he was suddenly stunned for the same reason as usual. Then it was over, and his hand was moving once more, smile fixed back in place.

Still, Tori knew what she'd seen.

"There you all are!" Kyle called. "Chloe took off like she was racing the ghost of Crackling Chariot."

"Sorry about that. Since these two have been up my butt about the dangers of going in at night, I wanted to make the most of our day."

Ellie shook her head. "They're absolutely right, though. I've been part of the evening perimeter team on a few shifts and seen people stumble out. Most of them didn't survive long enough for treatment."

"But there have also been three new capes who've emerged," Chloe countered, clearly prepared for this topic. "Along with reports of lesser treasures. It's not like everyone who goes in dies."

“Power is a handy tool,” Austin admitted, his voice steady and thoughtful. “I won’t lie and pretend otherwise. It can change your entire life, but that’s *only* if you still have a life left to be changed. It’s not worth that trade.”

In a roundabout way, Tori blamed Ike, the man who had been Presto, for the New Science Sentries tagging along. When Chloe had mentioned her intent to visit, along with Tori and Beverly, the trio of capes had been adamant about joining in. None of them said it, but she could see the flashes of fear and pain on their faces at even the notion of letting them go alone. They’d lost one of their own, a teammate and good friend. Now they had to face the possibility that anyone could be taken, at any time, and were overcompensating.

Still, Tori wasn’t going to say no to three more sets of fists in a fight, and no matter what assurances were being made, she *was* expecting a fight. Chloe was here for something, and if it was rare enough to come to Hallowville hunting, they probably wouldn’t find it while the sun shone.

Besides, it wasn’t as if she could stop them from entering. Even with just a skim of the information, Tori had taken careful note of *that* particularity. It was why the AHC had capes working the perimeter, yet never did they stop anyone from entering. They merely walked about, making sure everyone was informed, and then apparently recovered the survivors in the evening.

Another of Tori’s friends, Donald Moss—a.k.a. Cyber Geek—was in fact working just such a patrol at that moment. He was out with his own group: Medley, Cold Shoulder, and Hat Trick. The poor guy had all but fallen over himself apologizing for being busy, despite her reassurances that it was fine. One team of capes to deal with was already more than enough.

“Do you all need to change?” Chloe asked, plainly having noted their usual attire.

Austin sighed, looking somewhat abashed. “Standard AHC procedure is to enter Hallowville wearing one’s own costume. It allows us to keep the power set we’re most familiar with, and many have reported retaining stronger versions of their abilities than strangers wearing the same outfit.”

“So, it’s practical but no fun,” Tori surmised. “Sounds like the capes, all right.”

“We’re standing right here,” Ellie pointed out.

“And if you were the ones who’d made that policy, it would be a really awkward moment, but I’d still be accurate.”

Kyle’s laughter broke the slight tension in the air. “She does have us there. You spent half the van ride complaining about not getting to try new powers.”

“Maybe we can hunt down some good ones from the vendors and try something else tomorrow,” Austin suggested. “Procedure is all well and good, but we have our downtime too.”

It didn’t escape Tori that he didn’t offer to change their costumes for that day, despite there being ample people selling options with makeshift changing booths beside their stalls. The New Science Sentries were attending this on duty, even if none said it out loud. They were there to be guards for her and her friends, though, so Tori technically had no objections to sticking with the practical choice.

Still... they’d jumped to that idea very quickly. Enough to leave Tori wondering if these three had had their trip planned even before a convenient cover appeared.

The conversation devolved into a brief debate over the various powers each thought it would be fun to try, but the words soon petered out as they reached the edge of Hallowville itself. The road leading in was blocked by a massive wall of shadow, part of a vast dome that covered the entire town. Supposedly, it went underground as well, creating a tremendous sphere. Passing through it would put them in Hallowville proper, a world that was both theirs, yet different.

Chloe reached out and took Beverly’s hand, then Tori’s, forming a human chain as they drew near. The New Science Sentries did the same, with Beverly and Austin joining grips to link both their groups. Steeling herself for potentially anything, Tori took a breath and stepped forward with her friends.

The shadows stormed around her, through her, a maelstrom of flickering darkness and flowing momentum. From within, a strange new sensation began to burn, though not in an unpleasant way. It crackled through her veins, stretching up to reach her brain. As the energy augmented her mind, thoughts began to flow more easily, and she understood what this foreign energy really was.

Setlium.



The energy that empowered Agent Quantum, Tachyonic, and of course, Professor Quantum himself. Her costume had worked; Tori was now ready to walk a mile in the shoes of a legendary superhero.

And if she was *very* lucky, Tori might be able to snatch a few of his laces for herself.

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# 4

The first thing Tori saw upon breaking through the shadow was a large town square. Cobblestone streets wound their way out from this central point, nowhere near where they'd actually entered, stretching out into Hallowville proper. As for the square itself, dozens of people milled about in what, up until moments before, had been mere costumes. Grand arches loomed overhead, from which hung an endless array of plastic bats, pumpkins, witches, ghosts, and the like.

Resting in the center of the square was a statue of a grinning woman in an eclectic outfit holding a lit jack-o-lantern. Despite being made of stone, a real flame flickered inside. Tori could feel it, albeit faintly. Her usual connection to fire felt dim and muted. She wasn't even sure if she could still shift her form; that piece of herself seemed to have been buried under the new current of setlium.

Turning back to check on her friends, Tori found herself staring at a model of the town, only one with huge googly eyes sticking out of the top. Googly eyes pointed directly at her.

"What the shit stallions!" She leapt away just as the figure wearing a huge city atop his head staggered back, bowing and addressing her in a sing-song voice.

"Hello! I'm Halpy, the Helpful Hallowville mascot. Welcome to Hallowville! I'm here to help first-time guests like yourself, and I come bearing candy!"

A white-gloved hand extended out toward Tori, opening to reveal a glittering wrapper with "CC" on the label. Although her instinct was to

smack its hand away, she instead slowly accepted the candy, tucking it into her pocket.

“And I’ve got enough for everyone!” Halpy spun around, offering a hand to Beverly, who was giving off a slight glow thanks to her new outfit. It was a neat effect, but a pale comparison to the real thing, which Tori had witnessed much too up close and personal. Her roommate accepted, and Chloe was offered one next, which she accepted with a “Thank you.”

Only when Kyle, Austin, and Ellie had gotten theirs as well did Halpy speak once more. “Those special treats are called Costume Candies! Once you eat it, your costume will get a boost of Halloween spirit, and so will your powers. You’ll have to work hard to find more, but Spooky Trudy likes everyone to have a taste on their first trip!”

Barely resisting the urge to mutter about the first taste always being free, Tori watched as the New Science Sentries downed their candies without so much as a second thought. Only Kyle seemed to notice her dubious stare and offered an explanation. “We were told about these in advance. It’s another part of why most of us wear our own costumes in here. Supposedly, it’s a rare chance to see what you could grow into with more power. There are rumors some metas come back permanently stronger, just from better understanding their gifts.”

Chloe chomped hers down as well, with Beverly slowly doing the same. Tori took hers out from its pocket, contemplating the option. Perhaps sensing her hesitation, Halpy stepped slightly closer.

“There’s no need to fear! All candy is safe during the daytime. It’s one of Hallowville’s rules.”

Against the protests of her most paranoid parts, Tori began to unwrap the candy, revealing a pumpkin-shaped treat within. “Why don’t you tell us more about those rules, Halpy? Sounds like stuff we’ll want to know.”

“Of course!” Halpy saluted, banging its giant, town-shaped head with the gesture and very nearly toppling himself over. “Number one: no costume, no admittance, no exceptions. Number two: daytime is for treats and fun, welcome to all. Number three: night is for tricks and danger, open only to those of age. Number four: have fun!”

About the same as what Tori had read. Seeing as all of the others looked fine after eating their candy, she finally took a breath and tossed hers down. The flavor was... fine. A little sweet, a bit too chewy—nothing mind-blowing in either the positive or negative direction. When it hit her

stomach, Tori was briefly overcome by the scent of a cloudy autumn day before the sensation faded, leaving in its wake a distinctly increased flow of setlium.

Halpy was right; the candy had definitely made her stronger. And, probably just as designed, Tori's immediate next thought was how to get more of it.

"Do the candies we eat carry over from day to night?" Ellie asked, mind clearly in a similar place to Tori's.

"Day to night, but not night to day," Halpy explained. "Each sunrise, the games begin anew."

There went Tori's briefly budding notion of camping out in here for the remaining two weeks and gathering enough candies to be unstoppable. In truth, even if it had been viable, Tori doubted she'd be able to stay here that long. Too much magic for her tastes.

"So, where to?" Beverly's gaze swept the area, taking in every detail. "The roads leading out have signs by them. From here, I see markers for a corn maze, apple picking, and a hoedown."

"That's a *hard* no from me on the dancing," Tori piped up immediately.

With an embarrassed nod, Austin seconded her. "Not my strongest suit either."

"Mind if I give it a shot?" Chloe was tenderly poking the third eye in her forehead, which didn't appear real, yet certainly was plainly more than the same prop it had been minutes prior. A gentle blue glow radiated from the iris, pulsing several times as Chloe slowly turned. The elegant motion was swiftly undercut, however, when her foot got tangled in the hem of her flowing garments, which Tori was sure had gotten longer when they crossed over, and Chloe went crashing to the ground.

Funnily enough though, she landed with her arm outstretched, pointing directly down one of the cobblestone roads. "Guess we're going apple picking?"

Tori and Beverly were already reaching down to help her up, but neither was faster than Kyle, who had the advantage of super-speed. "Apple picking sounds as good as anything else," he said while bringing Chloe back to her feet.

A general murmur of agreement rippled through them, and the group started for the road. Something felt off to Tori, though, and she looked

around, trying to place what it was. When the realization hit, it only spurred to her to move faster, quickly rejoining the group.

Strange as Halpy had been, realizing that it had suddenly vanished was even more off-putting. The only thing odder than enormous eyes was not knowing where they might be watching from.

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# 5

No one paid the man on the bench much mind. Given the bevy of more fascinating sights, he simply didn't draw attention amongst them. In what had once been a park, the equipment was now made of living creatures, who laughed and played with the mix of children and adults who were swinging along hooting monkey bars or whipping down a slide that twisted and bucked.

Come evening, the tone would be far more sinister, and the man on the bench intended to steer far away from this area in particular. Given the size of some pieces, they'd be quite horrifying if turned loose. That was only one small part of his plan, what had once seemed like nothing more than a distant fantasy.

The candy changed everything. His own pitiful power, so flawed and limited, could at last be augmented. Designing a costume had been time consuming, but the bespoke patchwork suit proved to be worth every morsel of effort, fitting him with elegant perfection. All the while, he'd wondered if his speculation would bear fruit. One bite was all it had taken to understand the truth.

He was made for this place, and it for he. The way his power synergized so well with the surroundings... there was truly no going back. That came later, much later in fact. First, he had to get more candy. The initial boost had proven his plan viable, but it wouldn't be enough on its own. Judging by that first surge of power, he would need several more—not a small feat, given the candy's rarity.

Beyond that, he'd also have to snatch the necessary components when they presented themselves. Rather than pick specific targets, the man had

selected generalized powers to seek, enough to build an undefeatable ensemble.

When the chemical explosion in that costume shop first happened, he'd thought he was dead. Then, when he discovered his power of costume resonance, he believed a new chance had appeared. Only when the severe limits became clear did he realize this was no fresh start. It was just one more failure to list among his many.

Tonight would change that. He would take a better future with his own hands, finally putting that seemingly useless twist of fate to proper use. After all, what good was a power that gave him a faint echo of other metas' powers *only* if he wore a piece of their actual costume? Maybe if he'd gotten stronger versions, or if it worked with reproductions, but no, his gift gave him a drop of power for a mountain of effort.

But in Hallowville, *every* costume counted as real. All around him, playing on animated swings and swimming through a rippling sandbox, were potential costumes to snatch. Not that he could go grabbing them willy-nilly, of course. Even with the candy, he could only use so many at once, and selecting optimal targets would be essential. By nighttime, he'd need to amass a truly terrifying amount of power.

A trio of people in Lodestar costumes flew by, wobbling through the air with budding control. Much as the man would have loved to snatch one of those components, he knew better than to try. Anyone with power theft or mimic abilities learned early on in their research to never attempt taking on the abilities of Lodestar. The results were as consistent as they were horrifying.

How it worked in Hallowville was a mystery, but considering the potential consequences, not one the man was willing to explore. He had selected simpler, less lethal targets. Candy and costume components, that was the name of the day.

Rising from his bench, the man in a patchwork suit whistled as he strolled, hunting for his next opportunity. This would be the day he finally claimed his destiny. The day the world learned about the power of the meta-human named Fashionistador.



“You’re sure about this?” Quorum checked over Helen’s outfit one last time, three pins still held carefully in his hand. With his myriad of combat abilities, people often forgot that Quorum possessed a tremendous number of non-violent skills, as well—sewing among them.

The pair stood inside a blue tent at the edge of a Hallowville road, one of many where soon-to-be-guests were getting changed. Some were provided by vendors, but a great deal of the tents had AHC logos on their fronts. It was largely a public decency measure, as otherwise, there would be people changing freely in the open.

Helen hadn’t needed much help for this outfit, just a quick hem so she could run around if needed. The garish pink dress already poofed out on the arms and shirt, making her feel like she was walking through a marshmallow cloud. Her only hope was that it would feel more natural after entering Hallowville.

“It’s standard AHC policy to have a few of our more experienced people in there during the day, in case anyone needs help. Not many people have dealt with Spooky Trudy more than me, so I definitely qualify as experienced.”

“That history is the very reason for my concern.” Quorum tucked the remaining pin into a small cushion shaped like a pineapple, before stowing it in his open sewing kit. “She takes particular interest whenever you appear.”

“Which means it’s time she’s not spending messing with someone else,” Helen countered.

Shutting the sewing kit, Quorum looked her over one last time, reaching up to adjust the sparkling tiara resting in her hair. “I never understand why you so often choose magical avatars for this, despite your limited synergy.”

“It’s the only chance I ever get to see what wielding magic is like. Plus, it’s interesting to see how the different types function based on their sources. Consider it research, at the very worst.”

To that, Quorum chuckled. “I am not Professor Quantum; I understand that not all actions must serve a greater purpose. You like magic, perhaps *because* you are so bad with it. There can’t be many challenges left for the Lodestar.”

“More than you’d believe.” For a moment, the bespectacled woman’s tone grew heavy, her face suddenly looking far older than even her



holographic glasses could manage. Then it was gone, hidden away from the world once more.

“But maybe one less after tonight! You never know, this could be my year.”

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## 6

“Zombies Love Apples.”

Tori read the sign, hand-painted on a large wooden billboard just outside the orchard. Under the words was a childish drawing of a zombie stumbling forward, a bright red apple luring it closer. Further down, more words awaited, though they added less clarity than she'd hoped.

“Hallowville needs its apples to candy and caramelize, but the orchard is infested with apple-loving zombies. Luckily, zombies hate water, and we've got squirt guns to keep them at bay. Gather as many apples as you can, but be warned, the more apples you have, the more zombies will come calling. Apples can only be redeemed at the entrance, next to the refill station for your squirt guns.”

“Standard resource management exam,” Ellie surmised once Tori was done reading. “Sounds like the more you gather, the larger the threat, but timewise, it's still the more efficient play. However the prize system works, we can assume that more apples means more bites at the... well, you know.”

Tori found herself momentarily surprised that the assessment had come from Ellie; usually, Ike was the first one to pipe up. It was only seconds later she remembered the truth and understanding landed heavily on her shoulders. Ike was gone, and it appeared Ellie was stepping up to help fill in the gap he'd left on their team.

“Ammo will also be an issue,” Beverly pointed out. “Notice how they say the squirt gun refills are at the entrance? We should assume that means refills inside aren't going to be easy, if they're possible at all.”

As the team assessed the sign further, a cluster of families wearing various costumes wandered past, laughing as one of the kids leapt over the group, enjoying the powers imparted by a cartoon rabbit costume. They continued right on into the orchard without pause, leaving the team of pondering meta-humans behind.

“It is possible that we might be taking things a bit too seriously at this point.” Austin rubbed the back of his neck, hunting for the right words. “This place is dangerous at night—the briefings couldn’t be clearer on that—but daytime is another matter. Maybe we should just go play the game and see what we see?”

“That sounds lovely,” Chloe echoed. Her third eye blinked once and glanced toward the orchard, which seemed to indicate that it liked the idea. Or maybe that it hated the whole notion—it was hard to read the intentions of a single eyeball.

Leaving the billboard behind, the group strolled into the orchard, finding a massive crowd of people all streaming about. Some were in line, holding bushel baskets of apples, while others were filling up colorful squirt guns from a giant fountain. The majority, however, were filtering out through the dozen or so entrances leading into the orchard itself.

Splitting up, Tori joined Beverly and Chloe in acquiring and filling the squirt guns, while the New Science Sentries went to see about grabbing some baskets.

As they loaded their weapons, Tori had to fight the urge to study all the various costumes around them. The public’s love of superheroes was in full effect, as the vast majority of outfits were replicas of famous AHC members. Aside from the usual Lodestars and Quorums, there were other capes to be spotted as well. Three men dressed as Kicknominal were high-fiving over their half-full apple basket, while a woman wielding what looked like a small sapling as a club was clearly dressed as Big Swing, and there were no less than four Dapper Dolls dotting the area.

What surprised her more was the number of villain costumes also in use. Despite her hesitance to use it, there was a pair of Doctor Mechaniacal costumes in the orchard area, along with a Xelas, a Killcitate, and in an unwanted blast from the past there was even a Balaam. Sometimes, Tori wondered what happened to that piece of shit, and if he was still out there, suffering somewhere.

She certainly hoped so.

Thankfully, there were more than just capes and villains about, otherwise the place would have felt oddly like work. Costumes ranged from cartoon characters, to people from books, to something as straightforward as a dinosaur, though the man-sized raptor she spotted still possessed opposable thumbs.

Even for someone accustomed to hanging around a guild of supervillains, the sight was overwhelming. The amount of power it must take to fuel all these pseudo-abilities, Tori couldn't even fathom how it would be possible. Because it *shouldn't* be, really, except that magic was a cheating fuck.

With their weapons armed and baskets gathered, the team picked the emptiest of the paths out and entered the orchard. In seconds, the New Science Sentries had fanned out into a loose formation, with Kyle running a perimeter while Austin held the front and Ellie watched the rear.

For the first five minutes or so, they encountered neither zombies nor apples, only endless row upon row of barren trees. It was a somewhat creepy image, reinforced by how quickly the crowd seemed to dissipate. Despite so many bodies pouring through the entrance, in what seemed like no time at all they'd been pulled in different directions, making the orchard feel empty and abandoned.

Tori's best guess was a mix of sound- and vision-blocking wards, helping each team feel as if they were alone without stretching space so much that everyone actually was on their own. The second option was viable, just less efficient. Then again, it might depend on how much power this place was actually working with.

Finally, Kyle zipped back to their side. "Apples up ahead, along with movement."

Like the others, Tori brought her squirt gun to the ready. As she imagined firing, the angles manifested naturally in her line of sight, making it simple to deduce which shots would achieve maximum results. Waving her weapon around to test the feel, she found each movement oddly graceful, her limbs easier than ever to control.

Since arrival, they'd been so concerned with the logistics of Hallowville, there hadn't been time to properly test out their costumes' powers. With a grin on her face and a squirt gun at the ready, Tori prepared to see just what Professor Quantum's abilities were capable of.

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“On the left!” Beverly’s costume had offered her the power of flight, which she used to soar up and get a better vantage point as they approached the apples. The trees blocked a fair portion of her view, yet not so much that she couldn’t spot the shambling figures milling about. Yet despite her warning, no sudden surge of undead came. The zombies wandered off in the opposite direction, ignoring the group completely.

“Or not, I guess?” Lowering her altitude slightly, Beverly scanned around them, hunting for more threats and coming up empty. “Weird. It must have heard us, right?”

Tori was already putting the clues together, her brain whirring, when it felt like some unseen force gave her mind a little jolt. In an instant, the thought process was done and understanding had set in, although now, she was a bit confused as to what had just happened. Was that what it meant to have meta-genius? Some automated brilliance that connected dots for the wielder? Or was that just what her costume could manage with only a single candy of enhancement?

Regardless, she knew the answer and quickly shared with the others. “We don’t have any apples yet. Remember the sign? These zombies don’t care about brains—at least, not during the day. I’m guessing that if we’d had some heft in our bushel, it would be another matter.”

“We’ll get the chance to find out soon.” Ellie pointed up and ahead, to several bright red dots among the greenery. They’d finally reached an unharvested section of apples and promptly went to work remedying that.

Beverly’s flight once more made the ideal fit for the task, as she hovered in the air and tossed apples down to her waiting friends below. She

veered and wobbled frequently, the newness of the powers abundantly clear, but managed to hold herself aloft all the same.

They stripped five apples from the first tree and three from the second before Austin held up a hand. “Something is coming.”

Straining her ears, Tori realized that she could hear it, too. Her own power had never come with enhanced senses, so she hadn’t thought to test them out, but with effort, it became clear that three shambling forms were heading their way. Without fail, she produced her squirt gun, pointing it toward one of the nearing threats. “Finally! I’ve been waiting for a chance to really play with these powers.”

“Tachyonic and Plasmodia, can you cover the other two?” Austin asked. Even with no one appearing to be around, he wasn’t taking chances on using their real names. The New Science Sentries were slowly getting the hang of secret identities.

Both had their squirt guns already drawn, and a good thing, too, because seconds later, the first zombie crashed into view. It was cartoonish in appearance, with an oversized head and gray skin rather than open wounds and dripping innards. This was still daytime Hallowville, Tori reminded herself. Once the sun set, her version was more likely to emerge.

It barely got three steps out of the trees before Kyle had doused it in water, his shots coming fast and frequent. Each hit caused smoke to rise from the zombie as it yelped in pain, turning to flee. A second appeared near Plasmodia, who put a stream of water right between its eyes. The zombie staggered back, falling amidst the foliage before scrambling away.

Tori’s was the last to emerge, yet she felt only calm as her finger tightened. Before it had even fired, she knew where the shot would land and had made a dozen micro-adjustments before her second shot was sent. Each burst of water took the zombie in a different eye, eliciting the loudest yelp of pain yet, causing her zombie to totter off at an impressive pace.

“Okay, that didn’t suck.” Sweeping her arm through the air, Tori tried to hang on to the sensation, relishing the way her brain seemed to be analyzing everything. “Everything comes so naturally, like I’ve already had a hundred times to practice. These powers are pretty useful.”

“Well, good news! You’re going to have plenty of chances to test them out,” Beverly called from her elevated station, even as she plucked an apple and tossed it down to Chloe. “More movement. This time coming from five directions.”

Readying herself, Tori fired the instant another zombie appeared, taking it through its slightly opened mouth and causing a hacking fit, which was strange for an undead creature. Kyle and Ellie were in fine form as well, but there was no denying that the zombies made it slightly closer this time before the last one was gone.

“Bad news,” Kyle announced.

“You’re out of water,” Tori interrupted, having already realized the issue. “A rapid-fire technique makes the most use of your speed, while ignoring the issue of supply consumption.”

“After two attacks?” Ellie sounded incredulous; her own squirt gun was still well topped off. “Can you zip back to the front and do a refill?”

More rustling filled the air, and Beverly called out from overhead. “Holy shit. More of them. A lot more, and they seemed to come out of nowhere. We’re looking at about a dozen, near as I can tell.”

“Guess the orchard doesn’t like that plan,” Tori surmised. “All right, let’s make the most of what we can. Tachyonic, please switch roles with Chloe and catch what gets thrown down. Beverly, toss us your squirt gun since you’re on apple duty. Let’s collect all we can, but make sure to save some ammunition so we can punch our way out and make a run back.”

While Beverly and Chloe agreed with quick nods, the other three were looking at her with a smidge of uncertainty. It suddenly dawned on Tori that they weren’t used to seeing her take charge; that tended to happen in the Hephaestus side of her life. Finally, Austin let out a chuckle. “Seems like that costume might be bleeding through a bit.”

“Right? I almost expected her to start lecturing us on proper standing posture and citing some old ranged zombie-fighting formation,” Ellie agreed. “Though the real one would *never* use please during an order.”

Kyle snapped his fingers. “Yes! That’s what was throwing me off.” He seemed to notice the growing scowl on Tori’s face and quickly explained. “Sorry if you weren’t warned, but apparently, sometimes wearing a costume brings more than just its powers. Insights and mindsets are known to seep over as well, especially when there’s strong costume synergy.”

“Well that’s fucking peachy,” Tori muttered.

“And there’s *our* Tori.” Ellie threw an arm around Tori in a quick hug, visibly relaxing after the outburst. If hearing Tori curse made her happy, then Ellie was about to be overjoyed.



Because the next wave of zombies had arrived, and Beverly was wrong.  
There were definitely more than a dozen.

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## 8

When all was said and done, the group managed to collect thirteen apples. They plucked a fair deal more; however, once the squirt guns ran dry, escape became the name of the game, and it seemed like every zombie managed to snag one or two apples as they hurried past, even when Kyle held the bushel.

Nevertheless, it was an impressive haul, and upon returning to the entrance, their apples began to split open, revealing the treasures inside. Several held regular candy, delicious and non-magical, while others revealed free drink tickets for somewhere called The Bone Zone. One of the apples parted to reveal a squirt gun much like the ones they were using, only colored orange and black. Their next-to-last apple broke open to reveal a glowing light, one that faded fast as a Costume Candy could be seen within.

“Only one out of them all,” Austin said, picking up the apple. “Should we collect them until everyone can have another, or dole them out as we go to increase our overall power?” He plucked the candy from within the apple... only it didn’t vanish.

Austin was holding a Costume Candy in one hand and the apple in another, yet a still-shining Costume Candy clearly remained within the apple’s depths. A hypothesis sprang to mind, and Tori opted to test it rather than speculate. Stepping forward, she too took the Costume Candy out of the apple’s center, pulling it away easily, and again, another remained.

“I suspect the reward is for the group as a whole. We should each be able to take one from the apple.” Tori moved away so the others could approach, holding her candy and waiting to ensure the theory proved true.

The confirmation came in short order; Chloe was the last one to take a Costume Candy, and once she did, the apple in Austin's hand crumpled away to dust.

"Think it works like that at night, too, or is this because we're in the family-friendly version?" Kyle asked, his candy already unwrapped.

The group followed his lead, lifting their treats like shots and offering a silent cheers before swallowing the delicious prizes. Once more, Tori felt the surge of energy ripple through her body, leaving her even stronger than before. A small part of her wondered what it would be like if she'd worn her meta-suit, which was arguably the costume of Hephaestus. Would the Costume Candy improve her designs, alter the efficiency, or show her new methods of improvement previously unconsidered?

"Oh *yeah*. That is the stuff." Making a fist, Beverly lifted her glowing arm, testing her own sudden improvements. "I really wish we had a bench press right now; it would be interesting to see how much I can currently lift. Anybody want to arm wrestle?"

Austin grinned and started a flex of his own, before stopping. "I'm a little tempted, but we've only got so much daytime, so it's probably best we keep moving. Especially if we want more boosts before sunset."

"Not that we *have* to stay once it gets dark," Tori reiterated—a point she'd brought up several times in both their apartment and on their drive down. "Just saying, there's still time to call this off and stick to daytime treats."

"I'm sorry, Tori, but I do." Chloe's head was half-tipped in apology, yet her eyes were set and unwavering. "If you want to leave—"

"Fuck that nonsense in the ear. My goal here is keeping *you* safe. If that means we stay late, then so be it. Just pointing out that nothing is set in stone yet." Tori scanned the others, who appeared to be staying out of it. Except, with Professor Quantum's enhanced mind calling out the odd details in their posture and motions, she reached an unexpected hypothesis.

They were hoping Chloe would prevail. It appeared she wasn't the only one with business in Hallowville's darker half.

"Glad that's settled then, because we still need to figure out where to head next." Chloe turned around to examine the array of branching cobblestone paths leading through the grassy lands and promptly tripped on her robe. She staggered around for several seconds, cussing on comedic

theatre-level movements, before falling backward against a wooden sign. One that read “Maize Maze: Only a Short Stroll Away” in etched lettering.

“Guess I found our next spot?” Chloe rubbed the back of her head, more embarrassed by the spectacle than injured.

“Her last pick led us to a Costume Candy,” Ellie said. “Maze works for me.”

Everyone nodded their agreement, and after Chloe was helped up from the ground, they headed down the path toward the Maize Maze, wondering what challenge the next event would have in store.



Choosing a first power had been paramount, the decision that would dictate how the rest of Fashionistador’s plan played out. He had to strike early, before the targets had gained too much power, but the most vital aspect was choosing an ability that would help him gain more.

To that end, he’d held out when passing many tempting prizes, including a Tachyonic that looked especially authentic. Not until he saw the familiar silver shoes did Fashionistador allow avarice to take root. Shadowing the chosen guest—a slender, college-aged man with a group of peers—Fashionistador waited until he stepped away from the others, looking for a restroom.

That was when Fashionistador struck, tackling his prey from behind and roughly peeling the shoes off his feet. The struggle was fierce, kicking him hard enough in the nose to make it bleed, but Fashionistador called to the components, willing them to join his existing ensemble. At last, they broke free, the threads of his costume taking hold and weaving them onto his feet.

As they were donned, Fashionistador felt a new power course through him: the ability of raw, untempered speed. Many metas with super-speed had been known through the years, but these were the iconic shoes of Ricky Rocket, the man who’d run so fast he left reality behind. *That* was the sort of accoutrement worthy to join this ensemble.

Turning his attention to the guest, Fashionistador was surprised to see him suddenly pop out of existence, like he’d been wiped away by the world itself. Feeling suddenly unsettled, the shoe thief raced away. It was a pale comparison to true super-speed, but he’d only eaten one Costume Candy so

far. Now that he'd secured his first costume component, there was time to focus on gathering strength, while also keeping an eye out for more key costume pieces.

Behind, he heard raised voices as the group hunted for their missing member. The vanishing left him unnerved; after all, anything that could happen to one guest might befall him, as well. What would cause him to be destroyed like that? Pondering the notion, Fashionistador ran past a newly arrived group comparing their abilities, none of which were worthy of taking a slot in his ensemble. Halpy was with them, the city-headed mascot explaining the situation and handing out their first Costume Candies.

Seeing the town's designated helper jogged Fashionistador's memory, recalling the rules that had been explained. "No costume, no admittance, no exceptions," he mumbled to himself, chuckling afterward. He'd been worried that guests who'd been robbed might spread the word and hunt for payback, but this made things even easier. Once he'd taken away the core piece of a costume, the robbed guest no longer met Hallowville's criteria and was ejected. No one would realize there was any sort of threat until it was too late.

By the end of the night, Fashionistador would have assembled an outfit that no one, not even Spooky Trudy herself, could stand against.

# 9

The Maize Maze turned out to be more than just tall stalks of corn obscuring one's vision. Multiple paths wound through the field, leading to different exits depending on the turns that were taken. Every so often, the team would come to a scarecrow waiting in a clearing, held up on thick wooden posts. Upon a guest's approach, each scarecrow would raise their heads and offer a riddle.

The first such instance led to a lot of yelling when the scarecrow started moving, and Ellie had charged up a plasma shot that looked like it would cook right through the straw man before finally calming down. Only once its words echoed forth did they start to understand.

"My builder sold me, my buyer never used me, my user never saw me. What am I?"

"Coffin," Tori answered quickly, the answer feeling as if it had virtually teleported into her brain. The logic was all there—she could see the threads of connection that led to the conclusion—but it felt strange to not have a sense of doing the work.

Opening its mouth, the scarecrow spit out candy corn, one for each member of the group. Like the apples before, these wouldn't turn into true prizes until they exited the attraction. Thankfully, they were easier to carry.

Navigating the Maize Maze proved more time consuming than the orchard; it was less about sudden bursts of action and more focused on the cerebral challenge of finding one's way while tackling the riddles. Tori's costume choice was a big help with the second, though oddly, it didn't seem to offer her much in the way of mental mapping. She wasn't sure if that was an aspect of not having eaten enough Costume Candy to unlock it, or if

Professor Quantum just didn't have a great sense of direction. He was the man who'd mass-produced and popularized early GPS systems, now that she thought about it.

While the Maize Maze was interesting, it lacked the visceral thrill of combat. By the time they'd tackled the final riddle, "I am a Jack with a head, yet no body—what am I?" and Kyle yelled out "Jack-o-lantern" in his excitement to know one, everyone was more than happy to see the exit.

Their weariness faded swiftly upon exit, however, as the candy corn started transforming. Some turned to regular sweets, others into costume jewelry, and a few into drink tickets. The real prize was the single Costume Candy that each of them received, and the group wasted no time in devouring their next round of power-ups.

It seemed like they were having pretty good luck with the Costume Candy; every event they'd tried had earned one. Tori's super-charged brain was happy to point out that they'd also been following the guidance of someone in a costume with prophecy abilities, so perhaps it wasn't mere chance causing their good fortune.

Whatever the cause, she certainly wasn't going to complain as new power roared through Tori's body. She did wish there was some sort of gauge to know how close she was to the real Professor Quantum's power. That was the kind of information that could come in pretty damn handy one day, if they ever had to face the genuine article.

Leaning against a nearby wooden sign, Chloe had popped off her sparkling blue shoe and was rubbing her heel. "Sorry, everyone, feels like I've had a pebble stuck in there for the last few stretches. Really dug into my foot."

"I bet we could find a place to rest for a bit," Austin offered.

"Oh no, I can't ask us to waste our limited time sitting around in the grass. I'll be fine." Chloe pulled her shoe back on, poorly hiding her wince.

Assessing the situation, Tori felt the answer trying to bubble up, but she'd already put it together herself. Chloe's version of prophecy had been paying off well so far, and it didn't seem like a coincidence that she'd once again ended up near a directional marker. Besides, by this point, Tori had accrued a fair few tickets for free drinks.

"Why don't we check out The Bone Zone?" Tori suggested. "Setting aside the awful name, anywhere that serves food and drink is bound to have

seating, and this way, we'll still be putting our time to good use. Not to mention, your girl here could use a beer."

"I bet they have Halloween-themed cocktails!" Ellie said, her excitement visible as small sparks popped from her fingers. She'd never *really* stopped waiting for the scarecrows to attack and had kept herself ready as a result.

Beverly let out a sound that was part sigh, part chuckle. "I know it's Chloe's power leading us, but I can't help feeling you had a hand in getting us to a bar this early."

Even as she said it, Tori's brain flagged the error. Between arriving at, then getting into Hallowville, followed by walking between attractions, and the long journey through the Maize Maze, their daylight was running out. There was almost certainly still time to visit The Bone Zone, but afterward they'd be facing the prospect of dusk.

When night fell, the game changed. Both the risk and the reward. Part of Tori struggled against the idea that going to a bar with the last of their remaining safe time was a mistake; however, it was easily tamped down by her logical mind reiterating the success of having followed Chloe thus far. Wearing this costume, it somehow felt easier to push away the more impulsive parts of her mind, allowing simple analytics to guide her.

Useful, even powerful, but not a trade-off Tori was sure she'd make permanently. Gut instincts had kept her alive when fear froze her brain solid. While intuition was an unreliable asset, it was also a difficult one for an opponent to neutralize, whereas reason could be hindered by many external factors.

Tori was so caught up in her own self-assessment, she almost missed their first sight of The Bone Zone as they rounded a bend and came upon it. While much of Hallowville appeared to have been repurposed from the original city, this *had* to be an addition.

There was just no way a small farming town had a five-story club shaped like a giant skull, complete with a dance balcony jutting out from each of the eyes. Countless costumes writhed to the beat of what sounded like a techno-remix of an old Halloween song about a Samhain Sock Hop.

Nestled amongst the isolated, creepy small-town imagery, it was a strange sight, though an intriguing one. Reaching into her lab coat pocket, Tori clutched her drink tickets, eager to see what sorts of offerings were on



display. Before she could advance, however, a voice called out—quite possibly the last one she’d ever expected.

“Well now, fancy meeting you here.”

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## IO

Technically speaking, that voice belonged to Helen, a sweet-natured woman who'd helped out with the Starscout cluster Ivan's daughter was part of. What put Tori's nerves on edge was the knowledge that said woman could also, at will, turn into Lodestar, who was generally considered to be the most powerful meta in existence.

That was what Ivan thought, anyway, and given his standards for strength, Tori was inclined to trust her mentor's judgment. So, it was with a friendly smile in place that she spun around, the grin falling instantly as shock took hold. Part of her had assumed that Helen would wear a Lodestar outfit, like the New Science Sentries had used their own costumes.

Instead, Helen was wearing a voluminous pink dress that poofed out at downright impossible angles, with gossamer wings poking out from her back, topped off by a sparkling tiara and matching wand. Unlike the usual black-and-white magician's tool, this wand was long and metal, with a twinkling star at the end.

Almost as a mirror to Tori's own expression, surprise dashed across Helen's face as she took in the other woman's ensemble. "Professor Quantum, huh? Not what I'd have guessed for you, but there's certainly nothing wrong with the classics."

"It helped that I have plenty of spare lab coats," Tori replied, keenly aware of the others taking notice in her conversation. "I like your... cupcake fairy?"

Crossing her arms, it was an odd sight to see Helen's frustration paired with her comically cheerful ensemble. "Oh, come on. Multerion has had

this one forever. Surely someone else watched it.” She turned to the assembled others, looking them over. “Anyone?”

“My best guess is magical glitter princess,” Beverly offered up.

“She’s a witch.” Austin seemed to realize the sound of his words as they escaped, hurriedly rushing to add context. “A good witch, I mean! The good witch of the... sorry, been too long. I used to watch it with my... I used to watch it.”

The slight pause that followed had no chance to grow awkward, as Helen seized on it to step forward and introduce herself. “At least there’s one fellow cinema fan here. It’s nice to meet you all. My name is Helen. I know Tori through working with her uncle at the Starscouts.”

Everyone went around making introductions, while Tori tried hard to focus on the fact that half of them already knew Helen in her Lodestar form. Not that it would matter if she explained that, because no one would believe her. Just like Tori had been incapable of putting it together until Helen had transformed in front of her. That power of hers was a lot more dangerous than just flight and strong punches.

“—and so, we decided to hit The Bone Zone,” Ellie wrapped up. “How’s your day going?”

“Could have been better. I took a crack at the Haybale Coaster—figured ranged magic would give me a good chance—but the results were... less than thrilling.” From a pocket on the pink dress, Helen produced two cellophane-wrapped mints and a single drink ticket. “Truth be told, my synergy with magic costumes is pretty abysmal. Still fun, though.”

With a wave of her wand, Helen created a flickering rainbow that quickly frayed into sparks. “All right, maybe I need a Costume Candy or two.”

“We’re hoping there’s a way to earn more inside,” Austin agreed. “If you’d like to join, any friend of Tori’s is welcome.”

“It would be rude not to at least use my drink ticket.”

Together, the group moved toward the door, where a modest line of revelers waited for entrance. Looming before it, towering over all but the largest of costume choices, was a man who looked like someone had made a Frankenstein out of a professional wrestler. Scars covered his enormous muscles, and a pair of bolts stuck out of his neck below the electric green sunglasses covering his eyes.

He stood at the entrance, staring out at the crowd. Every now and then, he would motion for the next group to enter, which they did swiftly. No one made trouble or complained, and Tori noticed what looked suspiciously like a large bloodstain on the ground near the bouncer. Fresh or not, that sent a message—one that didn't require a boosted meta-intellect to pick up on.

Moving to join the line, Tori nearly leapt back when a shadow leaned out from the door. Living darkness snaked up the bouncer's arm, whispering in his ear. Tilting the garish sunglasses down once, he scanned over the crowd and nodded, causing the shadow to slink back out of sight.

"Good Witch, you go in. Are they with you?" He nodded to Tori and the others, who were suddenly aware of many pairs of eyes swiveling in their direction.

"They are," Helen replied automatically. "I don't mind waiting with them."

For a second, the barest of moments, Tori caught a shudder that rippled through the giant man's body. "No, ma'am. Instructions are clear. Please, come on through."

The way he hit that "please" could have been seen as doubling down on politeness, if one had missed the minor tremor seconds prior. All observational data indicated a potent fear at work. Being afraid of Lodestar did make a certain amount of sense; it would be lunacy *not* to fear anyone that powerful. But she wasn't the sort to pettily flex her might and shouldn't have inspired that kind of terror in a man merely minding a line, even if he somehow knew her secret.

No, the more likely scenario was that whoever had been controlling that shadow was the one he feared, all of which circled back to a central unknown variable. Who was it inside The Bone Zone that wanted Helen to enter as soon as possible? And how did they have so much sway?

As the group stepped past the huge bouncer and into the bar's depths, Tori lost her train of thought. Even with an enhanced brain, it was hard not to focus on the spectacle before her. Before them was an opulent club, as expected, complete with several bars and spinning lights, but in the center of the floor was a hole leading directly down.

From the entrance vantage point, one could see into its depths, to the people ignoring gravity to casually descend. Below, the space opened up into more branches, leading to different themed areas. There was a graveyard, a swamp, a suburban neighborhood, thick woods—and that was

just what Tori caught at a glance. Within each lingered different bar counters, and she suspected the music, ambiance, and overall environments would be just as unique.

Taking in the array of tunnels and the way their destinations were arranged, Tori felt her brain feeding her another realization. The layout wasn't random; it perfectly mimicked the human skeletal system—if someone treated each bone as a space for people to party. The Bone Zone wasn't merely a skull. It was an entire skeleton.

One where Tori had quite a few drink tickets to burn.

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## II

They toured through several rooms before deciding to plop down in one that resembled a haunted beach resort, complete with faded newspapers over the bar bearing tales of mysterious murderers roaming the sands. Although the magic of Hallowville hadn't replicated an entire ocean, there was a sandy area with an ankle-deep wave pool where one could soak their feet.

It was selected not for any particular criteria, aside from the fact that it was the first place where they'd spotted a free table large enough to accommodate the entire group. It had been strange, how empty so much of Hallowville felt, despite knowing the throngs of people making the commute to visit, a detail that rubbed against Tori's brain ceaselessly.

Now, she was beginning to suspect that the entire town was bewitched in the same way as the orchard, making it so the masses weren't aware of how many others shared their space—a magic that every theme park in the world would kill for, and yet clearly wasn't being used at The Bone Zone. Although Tori herself didn't quite grasp it, she was aware that club-goers considered clubs to be best when they were filled to the brim. Perhaps each attraction showed the crowd that suited it best?

They'd barely all taken their seats when a smiling young zombie woman wearing a tropical shirt and a wide straw hat came over, setting down margaritas in glasses shaped like shark skulls with their mouths opened wide. Sipping hers, Tori's brain thrust three facts toward the forefront of her awareness. Firstly, with the exception of some meta-variants, sharks didn't have skulls. Secondly, the margarita was absolutely

delicious. Her third and final fact was the only one she put voice to, however.

“We didn’t order any drinks.”

“No argument here,” their server agreed, setting down the last of the shark skulls in front of Helen. “Let me know if you need anything else.”

“I think we should be fine for now,” Helen replied.

“Actually, I could go for a blood orange martini.”

The voice caused everyone to turn because it belonged to no one in their group, despite having come from the end of their table. What awaited them there was a pale woman with a wide grin, black lipstick on her top lip and orange lipstick on the bottom. She was clad in a dress that clung to her curves, dark as night with bright pops of orange, and a skirt that flared out horizontally.

Before that moment, if asked, Tori would have laughed at the question of whether or not a zombie could turn pale. As it turned out, the answer was yes—at least in Hallowville. Their server nodded, then scurried off toward the bar. Their intruder looked the table over, then promptly ignored them all, her focus entirely on the woman seated next to her.

“You came back.”

“Couldn’t very well miss something like this,” Helen replied.

“So I thought, too, but after the last one... well, it matters not. You’re here, and even lovelier than painted by my memories.” Like a cartoon appendage, the stranger walked her right hand across the table on two fingers, inching it closer to Helen. “If you’d like, I can show you around, take you to the places almost no one finds. They’re gorgeous, and powerful, in a way so few can truly appreciate.”

“Guessing you’re a friend of Helen’s?” Austin rose up from his chair, falling back on politeness to resolve the awkward situation. “Pleasure to make your acquaintance. Tonight, I go by Agent Quantum—”

Like an alerted hawk, her head snapped toward him. Yet despite the harsh gesture, her tone remained pleasant. “Sit down, Austin. I don’t need the introductions. When you’re fueling someone’s fantasy, you learn a great deal about them.”

Tori had started to feel like she was racing with her own brain, that familiar crackling feeling running through it, but it was only three Costume Candies strong so far, and she’d already put the context clues together. “Be nice, everyone. Pretty sure we’re sitting here with *the* Spooky Trudy.”

Others did not react to the revelation with her same cool detachment, though no one went sprinting for an exit. What good would it have done? Spooky Trudy was widely speculated to have one of the world's strongest domain powers, an ability that let one rewrite reality within a specific distance. A domain they'd entered as soon as they'd set foot in Hallowville. It didn't matter if she was right there or across town, she could reach them all the same.

While Chloe was visibly practicing deep breathing and Kyle bounced his foot at super-speeds, Spooky Trudy shifted her attention back to the person she'd clearly come for. "Well, any interest?"

"It sounds lovely," Helen replied. "But I didn't come here to be where people weren't. Perhaps you'd care to join us on our own journey?"

There was a brief instant before Spooky Trudy responded, a micro-second where her expression shifted. Without her enhanced setlium brain catching details, Tori might not have seen it, and lacking the context of knowing people like Ivan, she certainly wouldn't have believed it. After all, why would a being of such immense power appear, however briefly, so lonely?

"Would that I could. That's the rub of this gig. I work so hard to make it exciting, but I can't play myself. It's no fun when you know where all the tricks and treats are, because you designed them. Not for me, or for the people tagging along. Sure I can't tempt you with a side trip?" Spooky Trudy leaned against Helen, a motion that nearly pushed her not inconsiderable chest against the pink-dressed woman.

"Sure as ever, but you're more than welcome to share our table for a bit. It *has* been a long while."

It was a statement most people would have considered odd, given Helen's youthful appearance, except it tied into her Lodestar power, so Tori expected that no one would notice. Their brains would skim past it, even if they tried to drill down—an unpleasant experience she could still remember from that side of the looking glass.

Ellie piped up, having downed a fair share of her margarita. "You know, I have to say, I wasn't expecting *the* Spooky Trudy to be so... well..."

"Queer as a skeleton in a Sunday hat?" Spooky Trudy helpfully supplied.

"Actually, that part isn't especially shocking. I was going to say cheerful," Ellie replied, her cheeks briefly turning candy-apple red. "Not to



be rude. I just assumed you'd be more mysterious and terrifying."

To that, Spooky Trudy let out a sharp laugh that echoed through the bar, one that ended just as their server deposited a martini that was a brilliant shade of orange with a river of red slicing through it. "Well of course, I'm friendly, dear child. I am Hallowville, and Hallowville is me. The sun still shines overhead, so naturally, I'm a treat to be around."

She took a long draw from her drink, the red lingering on her teeth. "Though we're getting awfully close to sunset."

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Bobbing for apples in a giant pool with toy alligators swimming about had gotten Fashionistador soaked to the bone, but the results were undoubtedly worth it. Not only had he lucked out and managed to nab a piece of Costume Candy, but upon exit, he'd found a guest dressed as Ghost Walker waiting for friends to finish buying various candied fruits.

Thanks to his newly boosted speed from Ricky Rocket's shoes, Fashionistador easily got the drop on his prey before they could react. The struggle was mercifully brief this time, as the wardrobe thief snatched away Ghost Walker's iconic belt and buckle—gleaming silver metal with a cloud of nebulous fog carved into the center. No sooner had Fashionistador seized his prize than the guest vanished.

Expanding his ensemble with more powers was crucial. However, they had to be the *right* sorts of powers. Speed was an obvious necessity, and now, he'd gained the power to turn intangible. That alone would make future thefts easier, especially when paired with his swiftness. Even better, Fashionistador felt the power surging through his current outfit connect to the belt as it was being donned, increasing its capabilities.

So Costume Candy counted for the user, and if their costume changed, then new additions functioned at the same level as existing items. Most people couldn't change their outfits in Hallowville; they were bonded upon entry. Fashionistador wondered if he was the first to discover such a useful loophole in the system.

Now, with a touch more power in his items and a whole new ability to play with, Fashionistador was feeling more confident. Thus far, his pickings had been slim; it was obvious that Hallowville's magic concealed the

masses of crowds which would have otherwise ruined the spooky ambiance, but he *needed* those crowds. With two abilities chosen, selecting the right final three would be paramount to success.

Something to call forth hordes at his command, a way to deal with overwhelming numbers. A power based on magic, so he could counter others with such gifts. And one to enhance his overall physical capabilities, lest he get taken down with a punch to the face. Of that last group, there was no shortage. He'd easily passed a dozen Lodestars, Quorums, and even a Jokull. While every power absorber or mimic knew that Lodestar was off-limits, the Jokull had been dearly tempting.

The trouble was, taking one of those powers meant ripping it off the current user and the stronger a target he chose, the harder a task it would be. That was why Fashionistador held it for later, waiting until he'd gained more candy and an array of abilities. He needed to reach a point where he could overwhelm that might, and then steal it for himself.

As the strains of music hit his ears and the destination came into view, Fashionistador smiled. Even from a distance, he could see the dense crush of bodies on the balconies, a massive buffet of costumes to choose from.

He was going to make sure to enjoy his time at The Bone Zone.



“So then, are you after any advice?” With another swig from her drink, the glass was empty. Spooky Trudy tossed it over her shoulder, where it was snagged out of midair by an oversized bat who struggled to keep the container aloft.

“All but Helen here are first-timers, and old enough to make the approaching choice. Will you stay after dark and dance with Hallowville’s other side, or run back to the safety of your world? You certainly seem to be building up power for *something*, but there’s still time to turn back.”

“I’m staying,” Chloe declared immediately. “There’s something I need help with, and this is the best chance I’ve found.”

“Well carve my pumpkins, you want something *specific*. That’s a taller order, you know.” Spooky Trudy held out her hand, just in the time to catch the new drink being hauled out by the same bat, who collapsed to the ground in visible exhaustion once the task was done. “Most who stay after

dusk have a generic goal in mind: power, adventure, courage—things that could be fulfilled in many ways. They can wander about, stumbling on potential rewards that satisfy. You, on the other hand, may need to be more targeted.”

“I’m sure they’d appreciate any help you could give.” Helen didn’t bat her eyelashes or slide over closer to Spooky Trudy, but she did remain as warm as usual. If anything, she allowed the woman’s overzealous affection to wash over her, peering past the theatrics toward the person inside.

Running a finger along the rim of her newly delivered glass, Spooky Trudy released a soft sigh. “I do like to give first-timers a touch of help, and if they’re friends of yours... a small hint wouldn’t hurt. After all, it’s not really *much* of a secret that there’s a nightly battle royale held in the graveyard, one where those with no patience for gentle exploration can push their costumes’ skills and synergy to the utmost limit. I suspect you’d find the prize to be exactly what you need, my little oracle.”

The chair squeaked under Austin’s weight as he leaned forward, his muscular heft straining its materials. “What if someone was after a different kind of goal?”

“I suppose it would depend on what that goal was, don’t you think?” Spooky Trudy licked her black-and-orange lips, revealing teeth that were dazzling white and just a hair too sharp. “Can you speak it aloud, sweet boy dressed as a hero, or will you continue to hide behind the pretense of duty?”

“You know why we’re here.” Kyle spit the sentence out like an accusation, yet Spooky Trudy visibly preened in delight.

“Mayhaps I do, perchance I don’t. Even if I claimed to, it would be unwise to take such a statement on faith. In the night of Hallowville, even prizes can be dangerous. Being absolutely sure you’re getting what you want is one step in succeeding safely—the easier part, in truth.”

Tori gulped down the last of her margarita and slammed the shark skull down on the table. “Yeah, yeah, the harder part is wanting the right thing in the first place. Genie movies exist. ‘Be careful what you wish for’ isn’t the original notion you might think.”

Spooky Trudy showed no annoyance at the jab, instead admiring Tori’s costume. “What an interesting synergy. Fundamentally, you should be connecting with it at a high level, yet you despise the avatar so much, it restrains your ability to draw on its essence. Because you don’t want the real Professor Quantum to be overly powerful, your version is more limited.

To make such a selection, and then entertain staying here past dark, you are quite the bold one indeed.”

Tori’s enhanced brain helpfully told her that Spooky Trudy might not have been *quite* so cool about the critique as she pretended. Given that Austin, Kyle, and Ellie were all looking at her with curious expressions, they were clearly wondering what sort of grudge she had against Professor Quantum, a meta she’d never even interacted with.

That was a concern for after Hallowville, however. Currently, she still needed to get them a lead on whatever mystery magic the trio was after. “You got a problem with bold? Given how you fawned over Helen, I assumed you’d find it charming.”

“That’s not the word most people would use for her,” Spooky Trudy replied, though her own eyes had once again wandered in Helen’s direction.

“Most people are fucking morons who can’t see what’s right in front of their face.”

With a small smile, Spooky Trudy turned back toward Tori. “Though you, of course, would never make such an error.” She threw her head back and cackled, causing the lights in the bar to flicker ominously. “Very well, Tori, you can have the treat. That battle royale in the graveyard, it has no set prize. The winner can make a request, and it will be fulfilled within my power to do so. Unlike every other nightly adventure, it’s the only open-ended treat out there. Have to make it tempting enough to draw a crowd, after all.”

The table lit up with several smiles. However, Tori and Helen were among those who grew more stoic, already grasping the situation before Spooky Trudy rose from the table. “Do keep in mind, though, there is just the *one* prize for our winner. Even though it seems your group has two different needs.”

Then she was gone, as suddenly as she’d appeared, leaving behind her parting trick and a second empty glass.

# 13

No one was in much of a mood for drinking or bars after Spooky Trudy's departure, so the crew headed back toward the exit. Tori and Beverly exchanged brief glances, but said nothing. They were both clearly working through the same concern: taking the best lead they'd found meant squaring off against their own friends.

Worse, those friends were a coordinated team of capes using the powers they were accustomed to wielding, whereas neither she nor Beverly were sporting their usual abilities. Granted, getting an echo of Lodestar's powers in the bargain wasn't bad, and Professor Quantum's talents were proving useful, but they had little practice wielding the borrowed gifts. Facing off against the New Science Sentries was a daunting enough prospect for social reasons; add in the likely defeat at their hands, and Tori was rapidly trying to conceive of an alternate plan.

Her focus was shattered as a gust of wind blasted over them, along with everyone else in the club's hallway, not to mention the dance floor, bars, and every other place Tori could see. The wind howled over them all, drowning out the music, conversation, *everything* other than itself. Through a nearby window, Tori could see several small figures swept up into the air, some larger ones trailing a few feet behind.

Slowly, the wind took on a new sound, that of a familiar, overly cheery voice.

"Hey there, Hallowville guests! Halpy, here, with a handy reminder. The sun is setting, which means it's time for our younger guests to head on home. The rest are welcome to stay, but remember, nights can get pretty

spooky in these parts. If you want to take your leave, just raise a hand and catch the wind. To those who stay... good luck."

Tori felt reasonably sure she wasn't the only one who caught a sinister tone in those last two words, but as she looked around to check with the others, she realized there was more at work than just the wind. All around them, The Bone Zone was starting to change. Spikey cages like sets of ribs descended from the ceiling; pits of what looked like boiling green acid opened in the floors. Worst of all, from the shadows, Tori could see dozens of thin, pale white hands climbing up out of unseen holes. Skeletons, of course—a countless number of them rising from the depths.

Whatever event The Bone Zone turned into, Tori wanted none of it. Grabbing Beverly and Chloe, she pushed forward, driving them down the hall and toward the exit. Helen and the New Science Sentries followed along. Mercifully, the wind slackened as they walked, though it was still powerful enough to pluck the multitude of raised hands off the ground and send them safely out the skull's eye balconies.

By the time they were stumbling out into the open air, the wind had died down to a mere breeze, one that was already fading. The change had only just begun, though. Before their eyes, the neat cobblestone path twisted and fractured, turning gnarled and overgrown. Shadows lengthened, deepened, and spread like mounds of dropped molasses. Lovely trees turned into looming husks, their sharp branches reaching out like fingers from the grave, eager to draw in company.

"Okay, so I sort of knew what we were in for, but this is freaky as hell," Ellie muttered.

"I'd say there's still time to bail, but it seems we're all pretty committed at this point." Beverly was always the more tactful of she and Tori, which was likely how she'd managed to touch on the issue facing them without directly demanding an answer.

Austin met the eyes of his teammates briefly, then spoke. "About that... we didn't mean to hide anything, but when we heard you were coming, I couldn't help wondering if—"

"Help! This freak is attacking me!"

The cry pierced the night around them—what would no doubt be the first of countless now that Hallowville had shed its wholesome daytime image. Still, there were some advantages in going first, like catching the

attention of a superhero team that wasn't exactly going to be mad about an interruption.

Agent Quantum was already on the move, though he was of course swiftly passed by Tachyonic. Tracing the speedy superhero, Tori found him arriving next to a man in a ridiculously garish patchwork ensemble. Most of it seemed entirely random, though the shiny shoes and oversized belt buckle both stood out. He was momentarily held up by a trio of small red entities that were leaving angry red welts wherever they touched. A woman with a glowing apron scrambled away, pulling out what looked like a cucumber and lobbing it in his direction.

Tachyonic arrived first, trying to restrain the attacker. His hands passed through the man, though, as if he were no more than an illusion. In response, the stranger moved at incredible speeds and socked Tachyonic in the gut. Although he didn't look too bothered by the blow, the fact that it had landed meant they were dealing with selective intangibility, which was far more dangerous than the permanent kind. That was bad on its own; stranger still was that he could move fast enough to hit Tachyonic in the first place.

Seeming to realize the fix for his dilemma, the stranger zipped by the floating obstacles and past the cucumber which had risen up and grown a pair of small fists. He raced right over to the chef, snatching at the knot on the back of her neck where the apron was tied. In a flourish of super-speed, he pulled the item free and fashioned it to his own body.

No sooner had the apron left her than its owner before them vanished, winking out of existence like she'd been cut between frames. The red floating entities and angry cucumber went with her, yet the apron remained, integrating into the mishmash outfit.

"Everyone, get back *now*." Although she wasn't wearing Lodestar's glow, Tori recognized the serious look in Helen's eyes as she barked the order, moving forward with her own wand raised. "I don't get the specifics, but he's somehow stealing people's costumes, and it looks like the powers along with it."

"What fun! Someone quick on the uptake." Having finished knotting his apron, the man turned just in time for a punch from Agent Quantum to pass harmlessly through his shoulder.

"Let's just say it's the wisdom of experience," Helen replied. "And, Agent Quantum, unless you want to add your powers to his, I'd really



recommend that retreat.”

“Him?” The stranger lifted his nose and sniffed in dismissal. “No, no, I think not. Tonight is the grand debut of the world’s greatest new meta: Fashionistador. Why would I sully my ensemble with a recreation, when the original model is ripe for the taking?”

Fashionistador’s gaze drifted over them all before coming to rest on Tori, the one who was dressed as Professor Quantum. “I much prefer going for vintage.”

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Before he made it a single step toward her, the meta who called himself Fashionistador was trapped inside a glowing pink bubble. Scoffing, he kept strolling forward, no doubt trusting in his intangibility to set him free. Instead, he bounced off, expression turning perplexed as he assessed the situation. Eventually, Fashionistador's eyes landed on the obvious source of the bubble: Helen's wand.

The sparkly star on top was burning bright as she kept her focus trained on the captured costume cribber. Bad at it or not, she was using magic, and as Tori had learned herself already: magic could counter effects like intangibility, usually at the least convenient of times.

"Quick thinking," Agent Quantum complimented. "While you restrain him, we can..." He trailed off, clearly realizing that the situation wasn't so clear-cut.

"What, exactly?" Fashionistador goaded, grinning within his bubble. "Arrest me? Assuming the outside world's law even applies in Hallowville, I've done little more than petty theft so far. Besides, how, exactly, do you plan on taking me in?"

With little else to do, Fashionistador began to pluck various foodstuffs from his apron, which Tori now recognized as part of an old villain's costume. It was a deep cut, one from the early days of meta-humans. While the wielder's name escaped her, the ability to summon living vegetables to do one's bidding was a power that people remembered. The trio of carrots plucked from his apron quickly grew arms and legs, their ends sharpening until they looked like living orange stakes.

“Nice as it’s been to catch up, I think it’s time we said our goodbyes,” Helen announced. “I’ll hold him in place, you all get Tori out of here.”

“Ma’am, we’re not going to leave you with this—”

“Buddy, I’m sure that Agent Quantum costume is urging you to do the right thing, and your synergy is clearly excellent with it, but if you want to really play at being a superhero, you should learn to think like one.” Helen nodded over to Tori. “Superheroes protect those in need. He was nice enough to tell you his next target, and none of you have any way to stop him. Not right now, at least.”

While Tori thought the false ignorance of his identity was a tad over-the-top, Helen clearly knew what she was doing. By the time she was done talking, Agent Quantum’s jaw had set in that overly stiff way it did when he got serious. “She’s right. We need to keep Tori safe until we find a way to counter this guy.”

“Got a plan for that?” Ellie asked.

“Not one bit, but we’re in a town filled with magic, monsters, and enchanted items. There’s bound to be something around here. Still, are you sure—”

“I might make this look effortless, but it isn’t. Time is ticking. Please go,” Helen urged. Sweat was indeed beginning to pool along the edge of her brow, and crackles were appearing in the wand’s glow. “I’ll hold him as long as I can, and then run for it. We can catch up later on.”

Though it visibly pained him to do so, Agent Quantum turned from the captured villain, looking to the others. “Come on, we should get out of earshot before deciding where to head next.”

The group filtered out along one of the broken cobblestone roads, Tori sending one last glance to Helen before vanishing into the now terrifying forest. As they left, Helen let out a small sigh of relief. These sorts of metas were tricky enough. The last thing she needed was Fashionistador powering up with everyone’s costumes and getting stronger.

Though, so far, he appeared content to produce his veggies, which were quickly crowding the pink bubble. Sharp carrots, potatoes with glaring eyes, corn on the cob that looked ready to pop off at any moment, all milling about at his feet, banging on the bubble, wearing it down. Fashionistador smiled as Helen turned her attention back to him. “That was very brave of you, sending them off.”

“Really more logistics than anything. If you know what an opponent wants, keep it away from them.” Helen drew in a long breath, focusing on the wand with all her might, willing the magic to keep working. As always, the metaphysical concept was fighting her, slipping out of grasp. Wielding magic felt like molding quicksilver, and not even Spooky Trudy’s domain could fully erase their incompatible natures.

The bubble would break, that was a given. Even if she’d had amazing synergy with the costume, it still drew on her willpower to wield, and everyone lost focus sooner or later. As it was, the slightest hiccup would disrupt her spell, and standing outside a giant club wasn’t the best place to focus, especially when Hallowville had just unleashed its dark side.

Knowing it was inevitable allowed Helen to prioritize making the bubble last for as long as possible. She held nothing back, giving no thought to the idea of a prolonged struggle. In the end, she was able to keep the bubble in place for over four straight minutes, easily the most astounding feat of magic she’d managed on a Hallowville visit. Still, the effort left her drained in a way that virtually nothing else could anymore, and when the barrier finally broke, Helen swayed slightly on her feet.

Before she had a chance to recover, Fashionistador had appeared before her. His hands snatched away her tiara before she had a chance to react, but she tightened her grip on the wand before he grabbed hold.

“I thought you wanted Professor Quantum’s powers,” she muttered.

“Oh I do, but magic is too potent to ignore,” Fashionistador explained. “And after you sent away my first target, I certainly wasn’t going to reveal my second.” He yanked on the wand, surprised to find Helen’s hold as firm as it was. Even without her Lodestar powers, her body was in peak physical condition at all times. Until he had a costume with augmented strength, Helen had the advantage in direct force.

That was what she thought until the first potato slammed into her stomach, at least. There wasn’t any pain from the attack, but it was certainly distracting, though not nearly as much as the carrots that leapt from the ground and attempted to jab Helen in the face. The corn kicked at her ankles, while vines from a squash were slapping at her torso.

The strange assault was an annoyance, but Fashionistador had more tricks up his sleeve. With a burst of super-speed, he wrenched the wand away, pulling it from her grip. In the moment before losing contact, Helen instinctively tried to reach for her real strength, only to feel Hallowville

shudder around her. In truth, no one could cut off Lodestar from her power, but calling upon it would shatter the domain's space nearby, kicking her out and leaving a dangerous break in the dimensional membrane.

That exact stunt was how she and Spooky Trudy had first met, so many years ago. Instead, Helen accepted the defeat, watching as the world went dark as soon as the wand left her grip. She was in the between space, the magic in her costume being drained away. Amongst that empty world, a familiar voice whispered in her ear.

“Sorry about this, but no exceptions means *no* exceptions.”

Just like that, Helen found herself standing outside Hallowville, the last rays of sunlight fading from the sky.

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The group didn't stop running so much as they hit a wall. A literal one, made of dilapidated wood, part of a modest-sized cabin that had twins dotting the entire area. Mist rose from the nearby lake, drifting toward a charred firepit dug into the grass, and sounds that could be footsteps or the sway of branches echoed from all directions. The setting was eerie enough to put everyone on edge, which in Ellie's case involved conjuring a burning ball of energy, better lighting their surroundings and preparing for whatever poor monster tried to pop out first.

"I do *not* like fucking jump scares," she announced, striding several steps forward and scanning about.

"Is it wise to tell Hallowville the things that scare us?" Chloe asked.

"That wasn't a request." The ball in Ellie's hand brightened as the energy intensified. "It was a warning."

Given how easily Tori had seen Plasmodia's beam carve through material much stronger than flesh, Ellie should be a threat to anything out here. Except they were dealing with the sort of unpredictable hooey that came with magic, meaning the monsters might shrug off the attack like nothing more than a light show. Somehow, it felt like her temporarily enhanced mind made trying to plan around mystical elements all the more frustrating.

"Tori, you're the one who knew Helen, do you think she has a shot at escaping?" Austin asked. His hangdog expression was plain to read, even without the extra oomph in her brain. The guy felt guilty for leaving someone behind to hold the line, especially since he thought Helen was a civilian.

“It wouldn’t surprise me,” Tori replied, choosing as honest an answer as she could swing. This was Lodestar they were talking about. Crappy costume powers or not, Tori was sure at the very least that Helen wouldn’t end up injured.

The response appeared to mollify Austin somewhat, a modicum of the tension in his shoulders slipping away. “Thank goodness. But until she finds us, we should keep moving. And to do that, we need to figure out what we *want* to do.”

In all the hecticness of Fashionistador’s attack, they’d nearly forgotten about Spooky Trudy’s bombshell. If everyone chose to look for the graveyard, it would mean pitting themselves against one another. Alternatively, they could split off and hunt for other options, though that choice seemed even less appealing with a costume-thief roaming around on top of the supernatural dangers.

“We could try to let Chloe choose again,” Kyle suggested. “Except for that last spot, she’s been pretty lucky at putting us on the right path.”

That was right... Chloe *had* been the one who caused them to visit The Bone Zone. And as Tori contemplated their situation, she realized that too had been a stroke of fortune. “I don’t know, I much prefer knowing about that creep in advance, rather than letting him catch us by surprise.”

“Look, Spooky Trudy said the graveyard brawl is at midnight, so we’ve got time to explore other options,” Beverly surmised. “But if we’re going to help hunt for magic treasures, it would really help to know what it is you’re after.”

Although her eyes were on the New Science Sentries, Beverly did send a few glances Chloe’s way, as well. No matter how they’d needled, Chloe had refused to explain what was driving her to take on Hallowville’s dangers.

For a moment, there was only silence, save for the disquieting rustle that came from somewhere in the trees, always out of sight. When a voice finally broke it, Tori was surprised by the source.

“It’s about Ike.” Ellie’s tone was steady, no tremors or tears hiding under the surface. She’d wept herself dry for their fallen teammate, the whole team had. “There are rumors that in Hallowville, with the right prize, it’s possible to speak with someone on the other side. Long enough to apologize, or say goodbye.”

“Do you really think that’s possible?” Tori had seen a great deal in her life, and especially since joining the Guild of Villainous Reformation, but even for meta-humans, dead was *dead*. If anyone had sorted out resurrection, they were wisely keeping that to themselves. Still, were Tori to believe any place might allow its residents to reach into the great hereafter, it would be Hallowville.

“Truthfully? No.” Ellie didn’t quite keep the bitterness from her words this time, or the sadness. “But if there’s any chance at all, we *have* to try. He’d do it for us, just to get that last word in.” A soft smile touched her face briefly, before vanishing.

Chloe’s reaction was quintessentially her. Without a word, she walked over to Ellie and wrapped the other woman in a strong hug, pulling her close. It was the sort of emotionally honest and sincere reaction that Tori could barely understand, let alone enact. The New Science Sentries and Beverly looked a touch uncertain, as well; none of them were as comfortable with open affection as Chloe. The momentary exception was Ellie, who leaned into the embrace and hugged back.

“I’m sorry,” Chloe said. “Losing someone you care about is... it’s the worst. With the time we have, let’s—BEHIND YOU!”

The scream jolted everyone watching, which was a good thing because it allowed Beverly to realize that Chloe was looking in her direction. In a burst of movement, Beverly flew forward five feet, not wasting the handful of seconds to move her legs. It was just in time, as a blood-stained shovel tore into the ground where she’d been standing.

Yanking it out of the dirt was a bulky fellow, at least by non-meta standards, with an old dog food bag over his head, rough eye-holes cut through the middle being his only means of sight. The shovel in his hand was weathered and dirty, yet the edge looked sharp enough to cleave steel. Letting out an inhuman wail, he lumbered forward, only to stop short when a searing beam roasted the grass in front of him, forming a line of fire.

“I *warned* you.” Ellie was crackling with power, the ball in her hand showing minimal loss from the opening shot. “Hey, Halpy! If you’re out there, tell us what’s the deal with monsters in this realm? Am I killing some innocent farmer if I cook this dude?”

Tori wasn’t expecting a response, which made her jump seconds later when Halpy stepped into view, like it had been hiding behind the nearby cabin, waiting for a chance to enter. “Not to worry! Spooky Trudy plays



fair. Since they're trying to kill you, turnabout is expected. Though Hallowville's attractions might borrow bodies, their minds are stored safely elsewhere, and all will be returned without harm when the season is past. Guests are another matter, though."

Their shovel-wielder let out a bellow and attempted to run through the flame; however, Ellie's beam was already in flight. It ripped him apart, cutting through his torso across the center. Rather than blood, crinkly autumn leaves spilled out as his two pieces landed inches apart.

Watching the effortless way she'd wrought havoc when given permission, Tori made a mental note to have Hephaestus steer clear of ever *really* pissing off Plasmodia.

It was an impressive show of power; there was no question there. Unfortunately, it also served as a dazzling display of light, the sort that drew attention. Tori could see the new shapes stepping into view. Some wielded tools, others actual weapons, while one appeared to be holding the dead body of a large turtle like a club. All of them shared the same makeshift head-covering masks and empty stares, however.

"Run!" Austin yelled, which served as a signal to both his group and the two dozen plus aspiring slashers who were approaching. Both groups broke into a sprint, racing through the summer camp, running for their lives.

Six meta-humans, five of whom had seen combat experience, should have been enough to rip apart any number of stumbling slashers wielding sharpened gardening implements. Unfortunately, that calculation ignored several crucial variables, such as the fact that three of the group members were working with unfamiliar power sets. Chloe's had no offensive potential, while Beverly and Tori had to adapt new tactics on the fly, rather than fall back on ones they'd honed.

Then there was the issue of raw power, as demonstrated when Ellie sent a blast behind them, cooking the arms of two pursuers while the rest simply shrugged off the attack. Much as she hated it, Tori's brain pointed out that this, at least, did fall somewhat into the realms of reason. After all, if every guest's costume was powerful enough to rip apart hordes of monsters after only three Costume Candies, Hallowville wouldn't be much of a threat.

Hearing the object slicing through the wind behind her, Tori easily projected its angle of impact and veered to the side, avoiding the sharpened garden trowel that sliced into a tree instead. The metal quivered as it sank into the trunk, and Tori tried hard not to imagine it piercing her flesh instead. She felt exposed without her meta-suit, or even her fire-form to fall back on.

Chancing a glance behind, Tori realized they were somehow running in circles—and losing ground. Up ahead was the same cluster of cabins near a lake that they'd initially stumbled upon. Hallowville wasn't going to make escape that easy, it appeared. Yet she wasn't sure violence was the answer either. Beverly was downing attackers here and there with a mix of punches and focused energy blasts, while Ellie was wearing the tougher targets

down, and Kyle and Austin were working as a team to trip and slow as many as possible. Yet their numbers only seemed to be growing.

A yelp drew Tori's attention over to Chloe, who'd tripped over a root, falling onto her bottom, putting her at the mercy of a slasher wearing a sack for disposable adult diapers and wielding a sharpened pair of hedge clippers. Acting before her brain could tell her better, Tori charged into the fray, delivering a punch that was meant to knock her enemy off balance, offering her a chance to scoop Chloe up.

Instead, the strike sent the would-be killer staggering back, bouncing off a tree before recovering himself. Tori's sense of wonder was short-lived, as the very same mind she'd been trying to out-speed reminded her that Professor Quantum possessed physical gifts as well. It might not be enough to snatch victory in a single hit, but Tori had never shied away from repetitive tasks.

She punched the slasher as he drew close, marveling at how easy the fight seemed to flow. Between her body's augmentations and her brain's ability to process information, it was comparable to fighting someone in slow motion, an opponent whose every move she knew the instant they started to make it.

With a simple series of jabs and one well-placed kick, Tori disarmed her attacker, snatching his clippers for herself. That didn't diminish his enthusiasm, however. He continued forward, trying to bludgeon her with his fists, so Tori opened the set of blades and snipped.

His left arm landed next to Chloe, who let out a soft shriek and kicked it with both feet, sending the leaf-filled limb rolling down the grass's soft incline. It tumbled most of the way down, hitting a series of small bumps at the end and bouncing itself slightly airborne. That touch of extra distance meant the limb splashed into the shallows of the lake, rather than remain supported by the grass.

No sooner had it landed than furious plumes of smoke started rising off the limb, not unlike the lake's perpetual fog. Despite the pair being disconnected, Tori saw the visible shudders of pain that ran through her enemy when his arm splashed down—the first time any of them had shown the slightest bit of discomfort.

"It's the lake! The lake burns them. We have to drive them in."

The New Science Sentries took only a moment to process Tori's outburst, clearly accustomed to the shifting chaos of a battlefield. Reacting

quickly, Ellie started angling her shots to force their pursuers toward the lake, rather than letting them scatter. Austin took a more direct approach, grabbing hold of a slasher he was fighting and simply tossing them down the incline. At the first splash, the would-be killer thrashed and flailed wildly, a moan like billowing wind slipping forth before he went silent.

More splashing came from further down the lake's edge, followed by muffled cursing. "Doesn't just hurt them," Kyle announced, shaking his left hand like it had been seared. "That water affects everything. We can't go wading in and hope they follow."

Thinking back to the apple-picking challenge, Tori's brain helpfully showed her recollections of other guests and their prizes, some of which were replicas of the squirt guns they'd been using. At the time, she'd thought of them as cute trinkets, yet now, Tori found herself wondering if Hallowville's own weaponry could handle such dangerous ammunition. Perhaps the daytime games offered more advantages than they'd realized.

Still, it wasn't as if they were helpless, especially now that they'd discovered a simple way to put their pursuers down. "Beverly, go high! Austin and I will toss them up. You make sure they fall in the lake. Kyle and Ellie, keep them from converging on us while we whittle the numbers. Chloe, do whatever feels right. Your costume hasn't steered us wrong yet."

Tori had barely finished barking the orders before her own hands were moving, taking hold of the one-armed slasher she'd saved Chloe from and hurling him up overhead. Though not fast enough to be a blur, Beverly still left a glowing streak through the sky as she snatched her first target up and flew him over to the lake's edge. Crashing through the lake's covering of fog, he let out that same windy moan before sinking entirely out of sight.

Briefly, the New Science Sentries hesitated, exchanging a look between themselves before the trio sprang into action. Kyle's speed and precise hits kept a multitude of opponents off balance, while Ellie let the bolts of plasma fly free. Most of the slashers still standing weren't injured by the attack; however, it kept them pinned in place by the sheer force of the impacts.

While they worked, Austin moved like a man possessed, grabbing and throwing attackers as fast as he could get them in his grip. Beverly zipped about to keep up, and while she might have dropped some of the slashers in shallower water than intended, they all dissolved just the same.

Working as a team, the six meta-humans were turning the tide. Grabbing hold of another body and hurling it into the air, Tori watched, waiting, wondering if the horde would break. There didn't appear to be any retreat planned; those that remained were trudging forward, eager to meet the same fate befalling their brethren.

Stretching her back to combat soreness that hadn't appeared, Tori chose her next targets of the many available. This was a chance to practice with the physical side of her borrowed powers, one she had no plans on passing up.

If these horror-movie wannabes were all so set on going for a dip, she would be more than happy to assist.

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Finally, the last weapon-wielding asshole with some sort of mask over their head had been tossed into the lake, a single hand grasping for them as it slowly dissolved into fog. It was quite the dramatic set piece—one Tori had no interest in lingering on. Fortune was evidently with her on that front, as no sooner had the hand vanished than a fire sparked to life in the nearby pit.

Despite the lack of logs, an inferno burst forth, whirling flames shooting into the night sky before slowly settling back to a reasonable blaze. After several seconds of burning, a *pop* rang out as something flew from the fire. Smoking near Tori's feet, she could make out the distinctive wrapper of a Costume Candy.

More *pops* echoed through the empty camp, candies landing by the feet of each person in her group. Tentatively, she picked it up and checked the item over. Once the soot was wiped from the wrapper, it looked the same as every other Costume Candy Tori had consumed, which was good news, overall, because she certainly needed the power boost, but still, it somehow felt like a letdown.

Why did they get the same prize as when their lives *weren't* on the line?

A final object flew from the fire before it sputtered out, bouncing off the grass once before Kyle snagged it out of midair. Small, dark, and metal, it was a tiny key, like one sized for handcuffs or a diary.

"So candy and a key," Beverly announced. "Anyone else feel like that's kind of a rip? Those things were trying to cut our heads off."

Since it had worked for her previously, Ellie clearly saw no issues with asking someone in the know. "Hey, Halpy? Can you explain how the prizes

for this work?”

To Tori’s mild surprise, Halpy once more stepped into view like it was hiding right out of sight, a trick that grew more unnerving each time she saw it. Was it magic, or was it really just staying that close, with none of them aware?

“My pleasure! Hallowville prizes relate to the games just like they did in the daytime. Play a game straightforwardly, get a simple prize. The greatest treasures come from wandering off the beaten path.”

An uncertain silence reigned as they parsed Halpy’s words, finally broken by Chloe clapping her hands together. “I think I get it! All the games have an obvious challenge and solution, like gathering the apples. But there are also hidden secrets to find within each game, and discovering them opens up the chance for more interesting prizes.”

Memories replayed in crisp detail through Tori’s mind, the easy recollection a costume perk she could definitely get used to. “Spooky Trudy mentioned that there were hidden places around, ones she said almost no one found. Which implies that they *can* be discovered, only that people don’t.”

Austin was already nodding along. “Sounds as though Chloe has it right, there were most likely other options during the assault. Maybe we could have searched the cabins or the woods, but we met the challenge with simple force and were given a prize that strengthens that strategy.” As if just remembering he had it, Austin ate his Costume Candy, causing a cascade of everyone else doing the same.

The familiar crackle of increased energy flowed through her, and again she wondered how far her current power was from the real Professor Quantum. Beverly’s glow had noticeably intensified, and Kyle was darting back and forth, testing his enhanced speed.

With her newest boost, however, Tori was forced to face an unfortunate truth. No matter how she turned the situation around in her head, there wasn’t any changing the analysis. “We have to find the graveyard battle royale.”

“It does seem like our best bet,” Kyle agreed. “But one of the other challenges—”

“The other challenges don’t matter. We won’t uncover their secrets,” Tori informed him, her tone even blunter than usual. “Pretty crafty of Spooky Trudy, I have to give her that. The only way to find the real prizes

is by ignoring the mission parameters and doing your own thing, exactly the opposite of how AHC superheroes operate. You all train to think in terms of goals and efficient operating tactics, which, don't get me wrong, I love in someone whose job is protecting innocent civilians. It just doesn't mesh well with exploring a spooky magical realm."

Ellie crossed her arm, chin jutting out in defiance. "We could at least *try* doing it the non-efficient way."

With a sigh that was more exhausted than anyone expected, Austin shook his head. "No, I think Tori's got us on this one. Maybe we could have tested that out during the day, but those weapons were sharp and real. The minute we start getting pressured and someone is at risk, we'll fall back on our usual tactics to protect them. Nothing in this place is worth one of *you*."

In the final sentence, Austin's control slipped ever so slightly, exposing the visceral pain he felt at such an idea. The loss of Ike still weighed on each of them heavily; however, none carried more guilt than the team's leader, the one responsible with guiding them through every battle safely.

If push came to shove, they would shove *hard*, and that was exactly what Hallowville counted on. While existing superheroes might be allowed to play her games, that crowd clearly wasn't Spooky Trudy's target audience. Well, with the exception of Helen, but Tori wasn't even going to try and unpack whatever all that was about.

Even the battle royale seemed like a lure, the longer Tori mulled it over. A blunt, simple method to get what one wanted, held late enough in the night for everyone to experience a few other challenges first. It was meant to draw in the superheroes and those like them, leaving the rest of the night for those more interested in adventure and discovery than triumph.

Which meant that on top of dealing with each other, they should expect other entrants to be capable combatants, as well—or at the very least people who had powered up with a good amount of Costume Candy. Not to mention, there was still that prick who stole people's outfits. Idly, Tori wondered if Helen was going to enter the battle royale.

A shudder ran down her spine at the notion. Crappy magical costume powers or not, Tori was in no hurry to face off against Lodestar.



Helen examined the stalls, hunting through their array of costumes. Like every other vendor set up outside Hallowville's borders, this one had several Lodestar outfits, though most were sized for children. Tempting as it might have been, Helen knew trying to enter as Lodestar would cause her to be spit right back out. The power within her acted as a light to Hallowville's shadow, burning away the dark webs of mystery.

She skipped the Lodestar outfits, along with costumes of Quorum, Cresscriss, Kicknominal, and even an old Apollo ensemble. There were options besides superheroes, too, of course: the velvet green of a Gecko Knight, the floppy-eared head of Justice Hound, and an entire team of color-coded combatants from a kid's show with low budgets and foam-costumed monsters.

None of which were much help against a foe who could steal costumes and powers. What Helen needed was an outfit that offered potent abilities, but which couldn't easily be leveraged against her. Powers she knew better than Fashionistador or ones that he wouldn't want to steal.

Obviously, there had to be a limit on how much he could handle, otherwise he'd have snatched up every outfit that wandered past. Being power-hungry and picky made no sense, which implied he *had* to be choosey, and hopefully he wouldn't add too many more powers before she got back.

Between the speed, intangibility, summoning, and now magic, it was beginning to feel like she was fighting a diminished version of Orion, and what a pain *that* had been. If not her own powers, then Helen knew the set

she'd like to use against such a foe. Sadly, those too would be out of reach in Hallowville.

Just as Helen was about to move on to another stall, something in the pile of costumes caught the light from the twinkling overhead bulbs. Peering down, she moved away the other costumes, revealing an option that had been buried on the floor.

Well, it was certainly a powerful option, and one Helen knew quite well. This was not an ability set she expected Fashionistador could quickly master, and in truth, it was one she wasn't even sure he'd be able to steal. What pieces of *this* outfit counted as essential, and would they even still be separable once she crossed over?

Experience had long ago taught Helen that there was no such thing as a perfect option, only one she could work with. The costume felt like such an opportunity, so Helen produced a handful of bills and paid before hurrying over to one of the many changing rooms that had been put up by the costume vendors.

After all, everyone knew you had to be *wearing* a costume to get into Hallowville.



Making it to the graveyard was unsettlingly easy. Though the broken cobblestone road led them within viewing distance of unsettling barns, a decrepit downtown, a broken-down amusement park, and an eerily normal suburban cul-de-sac, the group made no efforts to explore them, and whatever was lurking within let them pass freely.

With every step, Tori became more and more certain the entire point of the battle royale was to corral as many capes as possible. Taking them off the board would ensure for the rest of the night that everyone else out there was truly on their own. Superheroes swooping in to save the day might be a regular occurrence in Tori's world, but it was effectively the opposite of how things worked in horror.

Either guests would triumph on their own cunning and willpower or they'd fall. No one could say Spooky Trudy hadn't been upfront about Hallowville's nighttime dangers.

When the graveyard came into view, Tori was unsurprised to see a few dozen people already milling about. While they hadn't dallied, the roads had led them on quite the meandering route, as if giving them ample chances to try their luck elsewhere before accepting the inevitable.

The graveyard itself was far more elaborate than she'd expected. Some areas were so thick with mausoleums they resembled like concrete neighborhoods, and memorial statues covered the landscape. In many places, there was more stone than grass, though more traditional landscaping and headstones did pop up as one went further east.

"Clearly Spooky Trudy is a fan of New Orleans," Ellie noted. When blank stares met her declaration, she hurried to explain. "Sorry, I forget Kyle and Austin didn't get to travel much. Anyway, that's what the cemetery style looks like. I guess technically it could have come from anywhere that had to worry about flooding when burying their dead, but I'm sticking with my hunch."

Whether Spooky Trudy had cribbed design elements or gone wholly original mattered very little to Tori. She was far more fascinated by the people standing around in the graveyard. There were the expected smatterings of superheroes, including no less than five other Lodestars and funnily enough, a second Agent Quantum.

Other costume types were well represented, too. Tori could see three vampires, a Dr. Frankenstein with his monster, and what appeared to be a five-person pack of werewolves. Then there were the more specific characters, like the human-sized rabbit in a basketball outfit from one of those Multerion movies, or three of the color-coded members from *Justice Fight Squad 9*.

The more Tori looked, the greater a variety she spotted, until her eyes landed on a costume that was *much* too familiar. Granted, there were a few small changes since the last time Tori had seen it. The tiara, for example, was a fresh addition, though it matched nicely with the wand in his hand.

Fashionistador was there, and he'd stolen a key piece of Helen's costume. That fact sucked on multiple levels, because not only did it mean they were down an ally, but Fashionistador now had access to magic powers none of them understood.

"Damn that woman's love of obscure cinema," Tori muttered. She motioned to the others, pointing in Fashionistador's direction without turning her own head. Because the worst thing about spotting

Fashionistador wasn't realizing he was there, or even noticing the bits of Helen's costume.

The worst part was locking eyes, because he'd already been staring Tori down when she found him. There was no mistaking the hunger in that gaze; he'd made it clear he wanted her costume's power and wasn't going to take no for an answer.

So Tori met his eyes and kept right on staring back. Once the fight started, there would be more than furtive looks and posturing. They were going right for one another as soon as it was allowed. Flexing the metaphorical muscle of her enhanced mind, Tori began to run possible fight scenarios, picturing them in near perfect detail.

Time to see what Professor Quantum's abilities could really do.

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“Welcome to Hallowville’s nightly Costume Royale!”

Halpy was standing in the center of the graveyard, perched atop a mausoleum where everyone could see it. Tori hadn’t seen Halpy arrive, nor did she suspect any of the others turning to look at the mascot had either. Despite having a city for a head, Halpy moved with unnatural silence.

“Our rules are few, but each is important, so listen close.” Halpy’s voice carried over the still night air, easily reaching Tori across the distance between them. “The Costume Royale winner shall be our last guest standing. Any who willingly leave the graveyard shall forfeit, though entrants are allowed until a winner is crowned. Hold nothing back, for the magic of the graveyard will spare you from lasting death or dismemberment, turning those who fall into spectating specters. A boon offered only here, across all of Hallowville.”

That was a detail Tori hadn’t been expecting, though it had minimal impact on her overall plan. Professor Quantum’s potential for wide-scale destruction was limited on his own—that was where being a genius inventor came in handy, except Tori didn’t have any of his devices. Instead, she was going to focus on Fashionistador. The others could handle random goons in a crowd, but the costume thief was dangerous. If she could take him out, or even just keep him busy, it would make opportunities for the others.

“I hope you’ve all worked hard on understanding your costumes and the people who wear them. Spooky Trudy is watching, so be sure to entertain her well.” Halpy raised an arm and snapped its fingers, the sound that echoed forth like the harsh ringing from a warped church bell.

When the racket faded, Halpy was gone, and the fight had started.

Screams rose from across the battlefield as guests fell to surprise attacks. For a split second, Tori waited to see if the others would betray her. She wasn't expecting it; however, it wouldn't be much of a betrayal if she were. When none of her friends stabbed her in the back, Tori looked over to Fashionistador, though soon wished she hadn't.

A half-dozen vegetable minions surrounded him—cucumbers and corn, mostly—as Fashionistador waved his stolen wand above them. In a sudden flash of pink, each one grew to four times their original size, sprouting extra limbs that were oddly muscular. The squad of empowered furious flora fanned out, striking at every other guest within arm's reach.

One especially lucky cucumber leapt onto the back of someone in the costume of a pirate, thick vines wrapping around their throat and pulling tight. The struggle was brief before the pirate suddenly turned into a bright orange, glowing form and the cucumber tumbled through. Other orange glows could be seen popping up all over the graveyard—guests who'd already been eliminated.

"Veggie Reggie!" Chloe yelled, nearly causing Tori to jump in surprise. "That's where I know the apron from. He was a criminal from decades ago, and not a super successful one at that. I wonder why someone came in a Veggie Reggie costume?"

"Doesn't matter, we know who's wearing it now," Beverly said. She was floating above them, letting out a distinctly non-orange glow, when a human-bat monster swooped from the sky to attack. Beverly fired off a pair of energy beams, but the bat flapped to the side with shocking grace, avoiding them while closing the distance.

The collision sent both sprawling to the ground out of sight, several large mausoleums cutting off the distance. Checking ahead, Tori saw Fashionistador summoning more minions. As she'd feared, the longer this went on, the more advantageous it was for him. Every second he added troops to the battlefield made any chance at triumph slimmer.

Charging ahead, Tori left the others behind, trusting in the multitude of plans circulating through her mind. Even if she didn't like him, Professor Quantum was a member of the Champion's Congress. Surely his power would be enough for this level of threat.

Fashionistador saw her coming, reinforcing his next wave of troops with more flashes of pink magic before ordering them to form a protective wall.

The tactic was a sound one; however, it ignored Tori's current speed, both mental and physical. She easily calculated a path of minimal interference, bounding through the graveyard and up onto the stone walls, leaping along them with the same ease as taking steps. With her augmented body, it was a simple endeavor, as was countering the few strikes that were made by the fibrous limbs smashing in her direction.

She landed at Fashionistador's side already attacking, the momentum from her fall channeled into a well-aimed punch. The blow passed harmlessly through his chest, however, as Fashionistador's intangibility came into play. Tori had hoped that he was limited in how many costume powers could be activated at once, but so far, it was proving to be a false hypothesis.

Slamming her hands together, she released a small shockwave, pitiful compared to what real strength could conjure. It was still enough to test whether Fashionistador was affected, though. Intangibility was a broad term, and most versions of it still had some connection to the physical world. Her fire-form, for example, was weakened by cold, lack of oxygen, and other environmental factors.

Sadly, soundwaves appeared to be no bother to Fashionistador, who merely chuckled at the clap before launching a blurry flurry of his own attacks. While her borrowed powers made it easier to track him, she still couldn't keep up. Luckily, the punches he threw into her ribs barely registered, whereas hers passed directly through his skull without ever making contact.

Lashing roots grabbed at her arms and legs, twisting around to bind her in place. Calmly, Tori went to break the bindings so she could continue searching for a weak spot... only, they didn't give. It didn't make sense. She had Professor Quantum's strength. How could these pitiful little produce minions be keeping her contained?

"You really thought you could take me by yourself?" Fashionistador laughed, even as he grabbed hold of the lab coat on Tori's back, pulling it away.

As it started to give, Tori felt the power go with it, along with other mental aspects she hadn't even noticed. Scanning the graveyard, she spotted the rest of her friends cut off, held at bay by a combination of other guests and vegetable minions. Why the hell had she rushed on ahead, without even a concrete idea of how she would hurt her opponent?

Arrogance was the obvious answer; Tori could still feel it lingering in her brain like a bad aftertaste. Whether it was actually Professor Quantum's or was there because of how she viewed him, Tori had gone off half-cocked with an unrelenting certainty that she wouldn't lose, positive that the power would carry her through.

Instead, she was stuck on the ground, staring at her friends as the lab coat came free, casting Tori into a world of shadows, the cackling laughter of Fashionistador ringing in her ears.

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Watching Tori vanish, Beverly found two warring emotions fighting for control over her next action. The righteous fury in her wanted to shrug off the other two Lodestar-costumed guests keeping her busy, zipping over to smack Fashionistador in his smugly grinning face. The pragmatic caution in her, however, counseled a more thoughtful approach for one simple reason.

Dumb name or not, Fashionistador had taken out Tori with ease, and he was only going to be stronger now that he'd added Professor Quantum's lab coat to his wardrobe. The accessory had already integrated into his ensemble; she could see him flexing from across the graveyard.

Bolts of energy seared through the air near Beverly's face, forcing her to dive. The other Lodestars were troublesome, a mix of speed, agility, and ranged attacks mixed in with the ability to fly. No wonder the other villains hated facing off against the real deal—her echoes were annoying enough.

While Beverly wasn't sure how her number of Costume Candies compared to the competition, she did have one concrete advantage over the other Lodestars. Thanks to her time training as Bahamut, Beverly was well-practiced at flying and fighting, easily adapted to the three-dimensional battlefield.

With a carefully timed charge, she roared through the air, catching another Lodestar by the ankle and spinning her around, then down, like a human club. Beverly's captured foe landed at a poor angle, her neck smashing against the slope of a roof, and suddenly, the foe was a glowing orange ghost.

Although she quickly recovered, scanning for the other airborne Lodestar, Beverly was slightly shaken by the exchange. It hadn't felt like she was bringing the other guest down that hard at all; she certainly hadn't expected it to be a killing blow. Here in the Costume Royale, it was mercifully only a minor slipup, but that kind of mistake in the real world came with dire consequences.

Even scarier, if this was her power as a cheap facsimile, how easy would it be for Lodestar to kill someone?

Beverly said a silent word of thanks that power this deadly was in hands that used it carefully, even as she continued hunting for her other adversary. She found the other Lodestar eventually, or rather, the glowing orange ghost that remained of her.

A half-dozen other specters lingered around Fashionistador, whose army had swiftly swollen in size. Other guests had clearly noticed and tried to intervene, leading to the orange audience nearby. At least none of them were her friends, as Beverly noticed the rest of the team regrouping nearby.

She flew over, one eye on Fashionistador, who continued grinning as he added vegetable after vegetable to his ever increasing army. Their tactical options were as shitty as they were clear: either hold back and let him keep stockpiling minions, or make a direct assault and risk being eliminated.

Not much of a choice at all, as Beverly saw it. Their best chance was to act immediately, and as a team. Tori was already gone. Prolonged battle would likely only result in more losses. Besides, if she was going down, she wanted to land at least one good punch on that bastard's jaw.



Tori landed on the outskirts of Hallowville *pissed*. At Professor Quantum for being such a pompous ass, at Fashionistador for his cheap bullshit with the coat, but most of all at herself. She should have realized how stupid she was acting, splitting off from the others, favoring the mental scenarios where victory was achieved rather than the many that ended *exactly* like this.

Being a bit cocky and brash had been a part of Tori's prickly personality for so long, it was hard to remember a time where she felt comfortable

admitting sincere vulnerability. But the absolute arrogance that had clouded her judgment inside Hallowville... it was staggering how a mind that nimble could be so easily led astray from within.

It was, if nothing else, a fine reminder of the dangers of thinking any power made her unbeatable on its own. Something to keep in mind as her inventions gained potency and she ascended to greater heights. All of which was fine for a long-term perspective, but would do jack shit to quell the inferno of fury coursing through her veins.

Dusting herself off, Tori didn't run over to the nearest stalls so much as all-out sprint, her breath coming in rapid bursts by the time she arrived. Getting used to the boosts from Professor Quantum's powers had been much too easy; now, she had to rely on her own muscles and energy—for the moment, anyway.

Scanning the array of costumes, Tori didn't have any particular plan in mind. Considering how her last exercise in forethought had played out, she wasn't feeling especially confident, not to mention she was at the mercy of circumstance. Tori had to grab a costume as fast as possible and try to get back before the fight was over. Since she wasn't an orange ghost, there was still a chance Tori didn't count as eliminated, but it wouldn't matter if Fashionistador slaughtered everyone else.

As her eyes roamed the thin selection of choices, she saw nothing but dead ends. Another Lodestar wouldn't make the difference; neither would a Dapper Doll, or a Blunderbuss, not to mention the non-cape costumes. Yet it was among what she expected to be the most useless pile that Tori found inspiration.

*Justice Fight Squad 9* was a children's adventure show with costumed champions in color-coded outfits, the majority of which Tori didn't give a shit about. But the team leader's color was red, including his helmet, and this particular costume chose to represent that with a thin plastic mask with small slits for seeing through, all held in place by a rubber band.

"Give me that one, and a red pen." Tori slapped her credit card onto the counter, snatching both implements while the surprised clerk rang her up.

She hunched over, popping the cap off the pen and putting squiggles over the black plastic below the tiny eye slits. There was no effort for any particular pattern; in her head, the image was always a sort of mental gibberish, so Tori leaned into that. There was zero intent as she moved the pen. She simply stopped when the first felt complete, then the second.

By the time her receipt was ready, Tori held the finished product in her free hand. She snatched up her card and the slip of paper, then dashed for the edge of Hallowville as fast as her lungs would allow. Working as she ran, Tori slipped the modified mask into place. Without the rest of the outfit, it was no longer the costume for a member of *Justice Fight Squad 9*.

Instead it was a red mask with eyes that were pitch black, save only for the red runes in their center. There might be no such thing as an unbeatable power, but Tori had seen firsthand that not all abilities were created equal. Since Fashionistador wanted to play costume one-upmanship, she'd introduce him to the brutal fashion of her mentor.

Simple as it might have been, Tori had donned the unmistakable costume of Fornax.

There were just too damn many opponents. Between the magically enhanced vegetables, the other guests flinging powers around, and Fashionistador picking people off himself, Tachyonic couldn't make any headway. Normally, it was trivial to ignore the goons and go for the real threats, zipping across battlefields at speeds no one could hope to beat. Even other metas with super-speed could rarely match Tachyonic's pace, and those that could hadn't gotten Professor Quantum's intensive amounts of combat training.

But Fashionistador had the shoes of Ricky Rocket, and apparently a few Costume Candies to boot. Tachyonic attempted to attack him from the side, only to hit empty air as Fashionistador easily slid away in time—a move that wasn't even strictly necessary, given his intangibility power. That had been the hurdle Tachyonic was trying to circumvent with a surprise attack, yet he wasn't even fast enough to land a punch in the first place.

Tachyonic dearly hoped the difference was due to Costume Candy. Because otherwise, it meant that Fashionistador was faster thanks to the difference in their starting powers. On his own, Tachyonic had always known he didn't have what it took to match true top-tier super-speed, but his suit's constant setlium boost was supposed to overcome that weakness. It was still working fine as he made another run at Fashionistador, a series of punches easily avoided as his opponent smoothly stepped between blows.

Which indicated that even augmented, his power getting a constant boost, Tachyonic still couldn't match an echo of Ricky Rocket's speed. It was frustrating, but getting mad wouldn't help his team. Instead, Tachyonic

accepted his failing and shifted tactics. Agent Quantum had broken free of a carrot battalion, the remainder of their force giving chase on his heels as he raced for Fashionistador.

Tachyonic ran to intercept them, allowing his friend to focus on the fight. Although Fashionistador might be fast enough to dodge speedy strikes, the minions were another matter. With ample annoyance to burn, Tachyonic tore into the villainous vegetables. In short order, they'd been dispatched, so Tachyonic spun around to see how Agent Quantum's fight was faring.

Thanks to his speed, the turn was just in time to watch as Fashionistador thrust a hand through Agent Quantum's throat. For a split second, Kyle nearly lost all grip on sanity as the idea of his oldest, dearest friend dying washed over him like a putrid wave. Then the orange glow appeared, and he remembered that the stakes for Costume Royale were thankfully limited.

The blast of energy that ripped apart the graveyard made it clear that Plasmodia had reacted similarly to the sight, letting loose a beam of raw destruction that carved through guests, animated vegetables, and mausoleums alike. Sadly, the one person not affected was Fashionistador, who stood smiling as the energy passed through his intangible form.

An opponent they couldn't even hurt, friends falling around them... it was too familiar. Not again. He wasn't going to lose like that again.

With a guttural scream, Kyle charged for Fashionistador, hands already balled into pointless fists.



It was only as the first wave of pain hit her that Tori remembered why no one wore Fornax costumes. Stepping into the shadowy veil between her world and Hallowville, Tori's entire body was wracked with a sensation of ripping, tearing, being pulled apart at the very core of her being. The first round hurt, but was bearable. As she took another step, the real suffering set in, and Tori nearly staggered back onto her ass.

No wonder people refused to keep going, if that was what they experienced. There were other costumes of powerful people, ones that didn't make the wearer feel like they were being washed all over in acid. What even was that, anyway?

Steeling herself, Tori took a third step, unable to halt the scream that came ripping out of her throat. Her whole body had seemed to bubble, like water boiling without the heat. This was ridiculous. Why was Fornax's power so damn painful?

On the fourth step, the boiling didn't stop. That alone might have broken her, seeing the way her body warped and shifted, but Tori was well-accustomed to leaving the form of flesh behind. She wasn't mentally bothered by the sight, which was good, because physically, it hurt like hell-and-a-half.

Was this supposed to be a trial, the way Ivan had been forced to fight his way into becoming Fornax? A test of will, the way he had to battle for control of his own body? Or did Hallowville really just not want a Fornax around so badly that it was tormenting anyone who wore the costume?

Still, Tori forced herself onward, the sixth step causing her left leg to buckle as it lost cohesion. Everything below her left knee hung like a limp noodle, not even the bones keeping their rigidity. So that was it? Even if she pushed through the pain, her body would simply be left useless?

"Fuck you."

Taking a deep breath, Tori focused on a mental image of Ivan. Funnily enough, with the lab coat gone and the suit she'd had underneath, Tori was dressed quite like him on the day she'd first met Fornax. Ridge City besieged by rioters, the guild under attack, and their greatest weapon was lost in grief over the believed death of his children.

Terrifying as he'd been, Tori had also been struck by the overwhelming sense of power. Power that had slapped around an experienced cape like Apollo, power that made him impossible to cage, power that let him stand toe-to-toe against the strongest meta in known existence.

Power that *she* was supposed to be channeling while wearing that mask.

"You think *this* would be enough to stop Fornax?" Tori had no sense for magic, so she wielded it the same way she imagined Ivan would: by telling reality how things were going to be and expecting it to comply. "That's a god damned insult. Because if there's one thing we *all* know about Fornax, it's that he doesn't ever fucking quit."

If the costumes drew on people's collective perception, then that was the angle Tori needed to pull from. The tales of his ascension, the sea of broken bodies left in his wake, the failure of any cape to put him away. But Tori knew even more; she had context for those actions. She knew that

rampage was the act of a man pursuing revenge with unfailing determination.

Pushing her left leg down, Tori found it solid once more. The pain was still there, stronger than before, but it was no longer solely a contest of Tori versus whatever was pushing her back. Now, there was a dash of Fornax in the mix, and with power like his, a little went a long way.

As Tori kept walking, she felt freezing and crushing, shredding and spearing, perceived wounds that failed to manifest yet conjured pain all the same. Some were potent enough to give her pause, but at each turn, she remembered the core of her costume, the relentless drive onward.

When the pain suddenly stopped, Tori was confounded, at least until she spotted a familiar apple orchard, albeit one that had looked a lot nicer in the daytime. She'd done it. She'd made it into Hallowville. Leaning down, Tori reared back and punched the ground, curious to see what sort of muscle-might she'd be working with.

The enormous crater left behind by the blow caused Tori to freeze in place and take a long, steadying breath. Seconds later, she was dashing through Hallowville, hunting for the graveyard. Her laughter rang out freely, a mad cackle that put the few nearby monsters off from any thoughts of attacking.



Tori was gone. Agent Quantum was down. Tachyonic was down. And as Beverly failed to arrive in time, Plasmodia was speared through the back by a particularly large carrot-minion. The conjured henchman burst into flames instantly afterward, the layer of plasma acting as armor enough to destroy it instantly. Still, the damage had been done as Plasmodia turned bright orange and insubstantial.

Beverly landed in a flash of fury, crushing every vegetable within swinging distance. It wasn't enough to get Plasmodia back in the game, sadly, nor did it even make a significant difference in the overall number of minions. Fashionistador was relentless, flooding the graveyard with summoned servants, and his combination of powers made taking him out nearly impossible. Anyone who got close was out-spaced and avoided until they either retreated or ended up orange.

Not that there were many left to fight back. The only team member that might be left was Chloe, whom Beverly had last seen dashing to avoid a tumbling mausoleum, though Beverly wasn't sure where she'd be hiding. Counting herself and Fashionistador, there were about six people left standing, all being swarmed by endless vegetables. The only safe place was the sky, where a person in either an angel or Icarus costume was staying aloft on luxurious white wings.

Even that haven was compromised seconds later, as Fashionistador zipped through the air, smashing the winged guest in the back of the head with his enhanced strength. Plunging to the ground, those white wings vanished under a sea of fierce vegetable fists, only to arise in glowing orange hues seconds later.

A cut on her left leg reminded Beverly to pay attention to her own threats. The real Lodestar might be unbothered by such strikes, but a fractional imitation was still vulnerable to them. Stranger still, the more Beverly punched the pernicious produce, the weaker she felt. Like it was getting harder and harder to draw on Lodestar's power.

Screams from across the graveyard marked another fallen guest, this one using a power that allowed for the manipulation of multiple scarves. While the silken fabrics were lovely to watch as they danced through the air, it was no help against the crushing mound of minions powering through. Annoyed as she was, Beverly did have to admit that Fashionistador had come in with a sound plan. Waves of weaker opponents could still overwhelm stronger forces while wiping out the lesser threats. That left Fashionistador free to focus on the ones that were actual challenges, whittling their numbers from multiple fronts.

As she beat down the array of agitators nearby, Beverly barely heard the *whoosh* of wind before the impact came. Another punch to the skull, just like he'd used on the winged man, only her costume came with a bit more resilience. It did still hurt, however, not to mention send her tumbling along the grass as she was knocked spinning by the strike.

Enhanced speed helped her recover quickly; unfortunately, it was a gift her opponent also shared. By the time her vision stabilized, Fashionistador was already standing over her, a gleeful yet detached expression on his face. While he was obviously enjoying himself, Beverly wasn't any sort of target or highlight. It seemed he'd decided it was time to wipe out the competition, and she was just another minor obstacle to mop away.

And that *really* made Beverly want to smash this dickhead's skull even more. Sadly, her strikes were just as ineffective as everyone else's, passing through his intangible body even as he laid a second punch into her sternum. That one felt quite real, and shattered substantial bone. Wrenching pain radiated through her slowing heart, and Beverly had no doubt she'd soon be joining the saffron specter squad.

Much as she hated losing, it was part of competing. What burned Beverly up more was the idea of losing to the chuckling asshole standing above her. Sadly, they were all out of capes to come swooping in and save the day.

But not out of friends.

The explosion rocked the graveyard, sending stone, dirt, and at least a dozen vegetable minions spraying into the air. A cloud of debris swirled around the point of impact, obfuscating the source of the blast, but Fashionistador was squinting, trying to peer through. Taking her shot, Beverly swung for his back, only to hit empty air again.

Fashionistador didn't even bother to look her way as he punched Beverly in the sternum once more, his attention solely on the slowly settling cloud. As it cleared, a shape became visible within, that of a single humanoid figure.

"Did someone decide to arrive fashionably late?" Fashionistador threw his head back and laughed in the sort of overly dramatic fashion that gave villains a bad name. "Splendid! Just as the event was growing stale. I can't wait to see what costume you have selected." The hunger in his voice was evident, and Beverly's short-lived flare of hope dimmed substantially. Even if help had come, Fashionistador was just going to steal their costume, too.

At last, the figure in the cloud stepped forward, moving into better view. From the dark suit and red tie, Beverly initially assumed it was someone dressed as a banker or the like. Yet there was definitely more going on than anything that simple. Each step closer radiated out, like a wave of dread. Even the vegetable minions were backing away, creatures that had shown no regard for their lives so far.

When the new arrival spoke, Beverly knew Tori's voice instantly, except it wasn't *quite* that. It was her all right, but more so. Stronger, heavier, impossible to ignore.

"Hey, asshole."

The words sent shivers down Beverly's spine, and seconds later, she understood why. Tori exited the last dregs of debris, putting her costume on full display: the unremarkable suit, the loosened red tie around her neck, and the mask. The blood red mask covering her face, save for the eyes, where a pair of glowing red runes surrounded by darkness stared out.

Taking another step forward, she pinned her gaze on Fashionistador, flicking only briefly to Beverly behind him.

"Guess someone doesn't know his cape history. That's *my* nemesis you're fucking with."

There had been a real intent to take things slowly. Find her footing, get a sense of her powers, escalate as she got comfortable. When Tori stepped out of that dirt cloud, however, she caught sight of her closest friend on pseudo-death's door. Looking at Beverly helpless before a foe brought up too many fresh memories of a short cape with a crass mouth. It certainly didn't help when her friend gave up the ghost seconds later, turning into one more vibrant orange specter.

In a blink, Tori stood before Fashionistador. There was no way of telling if this power worked the same as Ivan's, but Tori had found on the run over that she could just *will* herself to be elsewhere nearby, like space was one more entity afraid to deny whatever Fornax desired.

The sudden appearance caused her enemy to jerk back on reflex. Intangible or not, the eyes of Fornax appearing inches away was enough to send anyone scrambling. Fashionistador recovered himself quickly though, moving back into Tori's personal space. "Look who's back! And in such a powerfully unremarkable suit. With that landing, I thought you'd have a costume that was haute couture, not the tragic du jour."

"I'm assuming that was some kind of fashion put-down, but truthfully, I don't know shit about any of that. Beverly could probably trade some fun barbs with you there." The grin that suddenly sliced across Tori's face was unsettling and familiar, especially to a world that had recently watched an attempted Wrexwren invasion. "Me, I'm just going to break your fucking jaw."

Fashionistador scoffed. "A threat as vulgar as it is usele—"

The reply was cut off by Tori's fist violently slamming into Fashionistador's stomach, sending him sprawling back across the graveyard until he flew through a row of headstones. They were unharmed, however, as he passed intangibly through the obstacles. Staggering back to his feet, Fashionistador no longer wore his haughty, invulnerable expression. For first time since they'd entered the graveyard, he was afraid.

"Seems someone needs a refresher on the perils of fighting Fornax." Tori didn't teleport this time. She walked, slowly and deliberately, moving ever closer to Fashionistador. "Point one, for example, is that being intangible doesn't do shit against his attacks."

That was a fact Tori had learned firsthand on the day she first met Ivan, when he'd challenged her to survive a single blow. Even as strong as she felt, Tori didn't imagine for a moment she was touching the real heights of his power. The more she saw of the meta-human world, the clearer it became just how high the furthest peaks rose.

As she'd expected, Fashionistador made a run for it. With her fists able to connect, avoiding those blows was the next obvious tactic. Tori watched as he sped up, not quite certain how this aspect of the abilities would work. It was a strange sensation, like she could see the world as a reel of film where one section was running faster than the rest. Focusing her attention on the faster section, Tori felt the speed snap into her chunk of metaphorical film, as well.

When Fashionistador ran up and tried to bash her in the neck, Tori was waiting. Catching his arm, she twisted it hard, hearing bones *snap* immediately. "Then there's the fact that super-speed is useless, because Fornax can match an opponent's pace." She released his arm, letting Fashionistador stagger back once more.

It would have been easy to kill him, in that moment. With a limb in hand, he was hers. But letting him go felt natural, like the only next step. The wary part of Tori's mind feared arrogance was seeping in once more, but that wasn't it—at least, not entirely.

"Get her!" Waving frantically, Fashionistador ordered his horde of minions to swarm, vegetables of all shapes and sizes running toward Tori, ready to crush her under their weight, if needed.

In response, Tori... ignored them. She strode forward, attention still locked on her target, the minions who stepped in her path exploding as her feet touched them, the remnants of their bodies spraying out onto the others,

causing them to explode as well, in a cascade of destruction that seemed no more than an after-effect.

The most acknowledgement she gave of their presence was with her next words. “This one is less a fact, and more a fun tidbit. Fornax hates dealing with low-powered fodder. He and I have that in common.”

Tori could kill him, so what was she waiting for? Watching Fashionistador blur into super-speed again, she suddenly realized the truth. Whether it was the influence of Fornax or her own anger, she didn’t want to just beat Fashionistador. She wanted to *break* him. Tear him down piece by piece, until he was helpless and afraid, power ripped away. Like he’d made his victims feel.

The trip attempt was pathetic, but Tori allowed herself to fall. She hit the ground and an instant later, Fashionistador was atop her, shrugging off the Professor Quantum lab coat. “I never thought you’d bring me something better, let alone of this grade. Thank you so kindly for your contribution to my victory. When I claim Spooky Trudy’s costume and become the new master of Hallowville, I’ll keep you in mind.”

His hands raced down to grab the mask, which Tori made no effort to stop. Instead, she laughed. Loud and forceful, wild and deranged, she let it flow as his fingers traced along her cheekbone, only to come away empty.

No, that wasn’t *entirely* true. There was a thin red film on Fashionistador’s fingers, a drop of which fell to the grass below.

“What the—”

The promised punch to his jaw shattered the side of his mouth while also sending Fashionistador flying back a half-dozen feet. Rising calmly from the grass, Tori paused to brush her suit off before walking over to her downed opponent.

“It’s not really a mask. Sure, nowadays he wears one, but the original version, the true origin of Fornax’s costume, was never any sort of fabric. It was the blood of people he’d killed. Because Fornax ends people in such a brutal, violent fashion that it just... goes... *everywhere*.”

With one kick to his torso, Tori exploded Fashionistador into the form of a bright orange ghost. The beaten man appeared relieved, his jaw no longer in aching pain. Rising up, he started floating toward the sidelines.

Until a hand grabbed him by the shoulder.

“Where do you think you’re going?” The sound of Tori’s voice froze everyone present, though Fashionistador looked like there was nothing he’d

rather do than run. “I already told you: intangibility doesn’t mean shit against Fornax.”

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“**W**hat... what are you doing?” Fear had found purchase in Fashionistador’s voice, his glowing form struggling to get out from the unyielding grip.

Rather than stir sympathy, the quivering in his tone only appeared to entice Tori further, as she pulled him close and whispered her reply.

“Being Fornax.”

Her punch to his stomach sent Fashionistador crumpling to the ground, clutching his gut as he rolled in pain. The blow didn’t explode him into chunks, but no one besides Tori knew if that was because she couldn’t easily kill him in this form, or if she was just holding back.

Stepping over his rolling body, Tori spoke again, this time loud enough for everyone in the graveyard to hear. “I have to tell you, I am getting pretty god damn sick and tired of people fucking with my life.”

“I don’t even know who you are,” Fashionistador spat, slowly struggling back to a half-risen position. He regretted that effort seconds later, when Tori kicked his right forearm, snapping it back at an awful angle and sending him sprawling once more.

“And? *You* still chose to get in my shit. Hallowville isn’t challenging enough on its own, you needed to come here and steal people’s costumes? Their chance at something the normal world is never going to provide?” Tori lifted her fist, the red runes in her eyes flaring ominously. “You made it personal, so I’m doing the same.”

“Tori... maybe you should let him go.” Austin was floating nearby; his ghostly form had made for a silent approach. “We don’t know what happens if he gets seriously hurt in that form. There might not be a fix.”



She stared at him, the dark pits of her eyes inscrutable, until a savage scowl snapped onto her brow. “That brings up a *really* good point. How did you know what would happen when you ripped someone’s costume away?” Grabbing Fashionistador by the shoulder, she lifted him up, holding his spectral form like he was standing.

“I’d already checked,” Fashionistador hurriedly explained.

“On *who*?” Tori yanked him closer, putting the terrified man inches from her blood-covered face. “On yourself, to be sure it was safe, or on some unsuspecting victim who fell into your clutches?”

Panic broke through the pain on Fashionistador’s face as he scrambled for an explanation, only to come up empty. “It was just some—”

“Some what? Some human without real powers to fight back with? What do you think I am under this costume?” Tori’s grip tightened and Fashionistador cried out, causing Austin to float slightly forward.

“Tori—”

“Can it.” Her tone was cold, her gaze focused as she dropped Fashionistador once more. “I am *done* with people thinking they can wield their power over me. Snatching me off the street, storming into my home... killing my friend.”

She leaned down, gently gripping Fashionistador by the back of the neck. “I think it’s about time to send a message to every two-bit cockwad who thinks I’m going to be easy prey. When they hear about what I do to you... well, I don’t want to give anything away.”

Pushing his head, Tori forced him to the ground until his nose was partly phased through a blade of grass. Only then did she let go and stand up, looming over Fashionistador’s prone form.

“Still, maybe it’s because I’m wearing the costume of Fornax tonight, but I don’t want to be done just yet. So I’ll give you the same chance the real Fornax would.” As calmly as if she were waving to a friend, Tori lifted her right leg, positioning her foot directly over Fashionistador’s skull.

“Go ahead. *Beg*.”

Fashionistador started to shake, his mind no doubt filled with images of the actual Fornax putting a foe in this same position only a few months prior. Considering how that had ended for the leader of the Wrexwren invasion, it was hard to hold out hope that the effort would lead to actual mercy.

Austin edged forward, hand starting to reach out. “Do you really want to do this?”

“Want to? I can’t fucking wait.” Her foot lowered by a visible inch, earning a squeal from Fashionistador. “Which means he better do a hell of a job.”

Desperation overtook reason as Fashionistador found his voice, the words bubbling out between fearful gasps. “I’m sorry! I know it was stupid, but my power sucks so much in the real world, and here, I finally felt capable of something. I wanted it to last forever, and I wasn’t hurting anyone! I wasn’t! They just got kicked out of Hallowville. Maybe the first was a risk, but all the others I knew would be fine.”

“Starting to sound like you’re making excuses,” Tori accused.

“No! Just saying that no one got hurt. No real damage done.”

“Because you got *lucky*.” Tori spit the word, her foot dropping slightly once more. “Lucky that Hallowville only gave them a gentle boot, lucky that you got stopped before really messing any shit up. Even now, fortune has your back. There are a lot worse ways to go than a swift smashing of the skull.”

Whimpering, Fashionistador curled in on himself, forming a misshapen ball.

“Please, miss. Please... I don’t want to die.”

“Should have thought of that before you fucked with Tori Rivas.” Her foot slammed down, easily passing through anything in its path.

The head of Fashionistador stared in open-mouthed horror at Tori’s shin embedded in the ground next to him, crushing the earth with such ease his noggin would have offered minimal impediment. “Remember this feeling, the next time you think about popping into the world of villainy. The powerlessness, the terror, the lack of ability to do anything but bear it—that’s what regular people feel every time you pull this bullshit. And some are fed the fuck up.”

Lifting her leg, Tori shook off the dirt, spraying it through Fashionistador’s intangible face. “Keep one fact at the absolute forefront of your mind: I don’t give second warnings. Not to you, or anyone else. You’re my messenger now, Fashionistador. Don’t make me regret showing mercy.”

With her grudge finally settled, Tori turned her attention to the graveyard and the few remaining competitors in the Costume Royale. It was

time to put this night to bed.

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Tori found Austin still floating nearby, only to realize Kyle, Ellie, and Beverly had joined him. The capes were wearing faces of blatant concern, whereas Beverly offered a covert thumbs-up. Putting on her best carefree smile, Tori looked at the worried superheroes and chuckled.

“Whoa, did you all think I was really about to smoke that guy?”

The trio exchanged awkward looks, making it clear that they very much *had* gotten that idea, before Austin piped up. “A costume that powerful is bound to exert some influence, but you’re right, we should have trusted our friend would keep it under control.”

“*Exert influence*” was one way to put it. Yet as Tori searched her mind, she wasn’t sure that the Fornax costume really had pushed her actions all that much. It felt more like she’d finally been given power no one else could challenge, freeing her to truly do anything. Even the begging hadn’t come from the costume; she’d purposely chosen to recreate Fornax’s recent exploit, playing on the fear all who saw it would hold.

“Yeah, I’m pissed, but not so much that I’d off a dude in front of a whole crowd of witnesses. I’m pretty sure that’s still a murder, magic town or not.” Surveying the graveyard, Tori found three other people still in the game. One of them, a man dressed as a fuzzy green-and-blue monster she didn’t recognize, leapt out of the graveyard’s entrance the moment their eyes met. He turned orange instantly—having willingly left the graveyard meant that he was out of the contest.

The other two—both wearing what appeared to be flamboyantly colorful ninja outfits of lime and lilac—vanished in clouds of pastel smoke. One appeared behind her, blade already thrusting for her spine. Tori let it

hit, enjoying the sensation of steel crumpling against her skin. A quick backhand was all it took to remove the lilac ninja, who traded her subdued tones for garish glowing orange.

The lime ninja sent shuriken whizzing toward Tori's head, peeking out from behind a mausoleum to toss his weapons. Like the sword, they shattered on impact, frail physical materials no match for the kind of power pumping through Tori. With a thought, she removed the distance between them, appearing at the lime ninja's side.

Grabbing his arm as he went for another throw, Tori yanked him forward, then took hold of his torso. With a single yank, she ripped her enemy in half, finding her hands empty as a surprised new specter hovered nearby.

Looking up, Tori waited for an announcement of victory, or some element to change. Nothing happened, however. After nearly ten seconds, Tori concluded that the fight must not be done. There was someone out there slinking around, waiting for a chance to strike. She'd find that hidden foe, the calculating, crafty—

Coughing and sounds of moving stone yanked Tori's attention back to the graveyard, where the remains of a collapsed mausoleum appeared to be rearranging themselves. That was, until a familiar head popped out, sweaty and stained with dirt, yet undeniably alive.

Chloe had survived getting buried by rubble and dug her way out. In a blink, Tori was there, tossing the rest of the stone easily aside and helping her friend stand up. There was a moment of shock as Chloe took in the new costume choice, breath suddenly stopping short.

"Tori... you look cool as hell."

"Tell me about it. I might have to try rocking a suit on my own sometime."

They stood awkwardly there for several moments, both aware of how this was meant to play out next. When one of them did move, it was Tori, who spun on her heel and headed for the exit. "Looks like you're the champ."

"You could win, though," Chloe called out, evidently forgetting what that would entail.

"Sure, but why? I don't like or trust magic. I'm sure as shit not going to make the most out of some mystical prize. All I wanted was payback, and I already took that."

Ignoring the whispers in her heart's darker depths mumbling about all the potential power she was leaving behind, Tori kept her feet pointed to the exit. Magic was enticing—feeling it run through her tempted even Tori—but it was also unreliable and unpredictable. The things Tori built, she understood through and through. What they could do, what they couldn't, and how they could be improved. Using magic would forever feel like borrowing someone else's power, whereas science was a tool she could make her own.

When Tori passed through the graveyard gates, it wasn't she who changed. Rather, all of the other orange specters regained their physical forms at once, landing with a communal *thump*. As for Chloe, she was lifted into the air by an unseen force, pulled to the direct center of the graveyard.

There sat the most opulent of mausoleums, one that Tori was certain hadn't been present moments prior. Stone that was dark as midnight, gold trim colored orange by the burning lamps floating all around its exterior. Its doors were bone white, and styled to look as though they'd been crafted from the stuff. Tori hoped it was an aesthetic choice, anyway.

With an ominous creak, the doors parted, tendrils of shadow drifting out like umbral smoke. From those obscured depths stepped a familiar figure. Her outfit was much the same, yet she wore it differently, every step smooth and deliberate. Spooky Trudy was no longer the chipper tagalong at their table entertaining herself with mischief.

This was the ruler of Hallowville, the meta in possession of a domain power without any known equal. Her softly glowing eyes took in the scene before a hand made of oozing darkness emerged from the mausoleum doors. It was tremendous, yet gripped Spooky Trudy with the utmost care as it plucked her from the ground and rose toward the heavens.

Only when she was eye level with Chloe's floating form did Spooky Trudy stop. "What an entertaining event you all put on. I am quite pleased, quite pleased indeed. So many insights gained, to yourselves and to others. Now, all that remains before the Costume Royale comes to an end is the offering of prizes."

She leaned across the divide between her and Chloe, close enough to whisper, even as the entire graveyard heard the words in perfect clarity.

"So, what will you wish for?"

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Like Spooky Trudy, Chloe's words were softly spoken, yet magically carried to every ear present. Even if they hadn't been, Tori could have guessed what she was saying from the furtive glances she kept sending the New Science Sentries.

"Earlier this year, we... we lost a friend," Chloe began.

"I am well aware of Presto's fate. Many have worn his costume this Halloween season," Spooky Trudy replied.

The tidbit drew an unexpected snuffle from Kyle, whose hands moved at super-speed to wipe his face.

Nodding, Chloe straightened her back, visibly steeling her resolve. "I was wondering if there was a way to talk to him, one more time?"

Despite all the determination Chloe must have mustered, Spooky Trudy shook her head. "This one again. I'm sorry, dear, but the prize must be something I can grant. Even the grasp of Hallowville has limits. Where your friend has gone, my magic cannot reach."

"Oh." Chloe's stiff spine sagged in response. Below her, Ellie leaned heavily on Austin, while Kyle just stared at the ground.

It was a noble gesture, offering up a prize she clearly valued to soothe the others' pain. But the world didn't always care about such kind intentions. Horrible as she felt, Tori was glad for the answer, too. She *wanted* magic to have limits, and the finality of the grave seemed like a pretty sensible place to start. Granted, those feelings might have been different if an invitation to talk with her parents had been extended, a line of thought she purposely avoided dwelling on.



“In that case, there’s something I need to see. Or maybe someone? I’m not sure how to put it, but—”

From nowhere, Spooky Trudy produced a small object, one that Tori’s eyes could somehow easily make out despite the distance. Dark on the outside, with a shiny center, she was giving Chloe a mirror.

“When you’re ready, this will show what you’re looking for. A word of caution, though, for tonight’s victor and a friend of my favorite guest: be certain you *are* ready to face what will be seen.” Spooky Trudy handed over the mirror, twisting to look into the distance. “Speaking of, she always loves making an entrance.”

Tori followed her gaze, discovering a burning metal object approaching at high speeds. It came to a sudden halt inches after entering the graveyard, offering a better look at the design. As it turned out, the object was a metallic person, one extremely similar in design to a robotic villain who Tori was quite familiar with. The only differences were aesthetic, the face of this one resembling... Helen?

“Is everyone okay?” Helen asked, doing a double-take when her gaze landed on Tori. “I tried to get here as fast as possible, but *somehow* couldn’t find the place.”

“Spare me the indignity.” The shadowy hands clutching Spooky Trudy slowly lowered her down, bringing her closer to the currently mechanical Helen. “Hallowville is a place of deeper understanding. What potential lies in one’s enemies, allies, even one’s self? One who tips the scales too far robs these guests of a chance to push their limits and find new truths about themselves.”

Landing inches from Helen, Spooky Trudy ran a pale finger along her shiny shoulder. “Not to mention, it wouldn’t have been *nearly* as much fun.”

Chloe was starting to descend, floating back toward the ground, though she stowed her mirror in her costume robes before touching down. In a blink, Tori was at her side, just in case anyone got cute ideas of making one last play for a magical boon. She was going to miss that ability once they left Hallowville; maybe it was something to work toward with her suit. Plenty of metas through history had rigged up teleportation tech—supposedly, the big limit was in how much energy was needed to make it function.

Filing that notion away for later, she checked her friend over, seeing that Chloe wasn't even dirty from her time being buried anymore. The dust had been wiped away, leaving her looking pristine. Everyone else was in a similar state; evidently, changing back from ghost-form came with a cleaning cycle.

Beverly's spotless face was knotted in confusion as she approached, though. "How the hell are you pulling out so much power? Between the two of us, I'm the one wearing the stronger costume, but that was just... damn."

"Some powers just work better on others," Tori explained, an excuse she'd prepared in her journey over. "The biggest issue with Fashionistador was the ways he had to avoid injury. Intangibility is famously one of the abilities Lodestar has issues countering; it's why she had so much trouble with Orion. Add in super-speed and magic, and there aren't many metas who could even hit him. Then he had Professor Quantum's durability mixed in to endure the blows. I just picked a costume that could overcome all of those elements."

"A costume I thought no one could wear." Kyle had wandered over with Ellie and Austin, though Tori noticed that they were still standing a few feet further back than normal.

For that, Tori hadn't really come up with a good explanation, so she'd settled on one that wouldn't require elaboration. "Don't know what to tell you. I guess they didn't want it bad enough."

Laughter came first from Austin, then Beverly, and afterwards, it was hard to say, as the stress of the day left them at least chuckling, basking in the utter madness of it all.

When it finally died down, Ellie piped up. "It is really impressive that you were able to tap into Fornax's power. It's also *terrifying*, if no one has mentioned that. Just standing near you makes the little hairs on my arm stand up."

"Ah, don't worry. Under the murderous magic and unnatural eyes, it's still the same old Tori here." That response was comforting for most of the group, as only Beverly truly understood the words' meaning, and she had no need for soothing in the first place.

A sudden yelp from near the graveyard gates grabbed everyone's attention; they *were* still in Hollowville at night, after all. As it turned out, the noise came from Fashionistador himself, who was trying to slink off out

of sight. However, a wall of shadow had sprung up from the ground, cutting off his escape.

One by one, all eyes turned to Spooky Trudy, who was visibly waiting for their attention. Only once she held them all captivated did the ruler of Hallowville finally offer explanation.

“Ah yes, I nearly forgot to mention, there is just *one* more aspect to this event.”

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From behind Spooky Trudy rose a giant shape, shooting up at incredible speeds despite the tremendous mass. In seconds, they were staring at a clock tower, one whose face was styled to look like an iron bat, with each of the “hands” instead being a long and short wing.

“While I appreciate everyone turning out for this evening, I’m afraid that the Costume Royale is what we call around here a ‘closer’ event. Participating means betting the remainder of the night’s opportunities in return for such a straightforward challenge. You are all welcome to return for another day, and night, of revelry of course. But for you, this eve has reached its conclusion.”

Behind her, the bat-clock started to move, its wings picking up speed. Overhead, Tori could see the clouds speeding up, causing the overcast sky to appear as if it were boiling. “Holy shit, she has time control in here? That’s a whole other layer of nuts.”

“It’s more time redistribution,” Helen said, wandering over and into the conversation. Up close, the similarities were undeniable; Helen had definitely used a Xelas costume for her reentry. “All around Hallowville, Spooky Trudy is stretching out moments and encounters so they last as long as needed, but that extra time has to come from somewhere.”

“So she boots us to the end while getting a material she needs elsewhere.” Beverly stared up at the clock, her small frown nearly imperceptible. “It’s efficient, I’ll give her that.”

Tori stared at her friend in a Lodestar costume standing next to the actual Lodestar, who was dressed up like a famous super-villain. At some point, when she wasn’t paying attention, her life had gotten extraordinarily

complicated. With no other options for recourse, she merely laughed to herself, a sound that came out more ominous when paired with her Fornax costume.

“Hey, Chloe,” Austin said, ignoring the clock development entirely. “I just wanted to thank you for what you tried to do back there.”

“Sorry it didn’t work.” Lacking super-speed, Chloe didn’t bother to hide dabbing the small amount of tears from her eyes. “I miss him, too.”

“Yeah, but you still tried. We *won’t* forget that. I promise.”

The two embraced in a strong hug, a gesture that caused the less emotionally open around them to look for immediate distractions.

With the clock spinning freely, Tori tooled about doing flips and jumps, enjoying the freedom of her incredible might for the short while it lasted. It would be interesting to know just how far from Ivan’s real power she was; she’d even take a rough percentage. The experience overall left her aware of how much development the muscle-system in her meta-suit truly needed.

Tori had no idea how mechanical systems were able to withstand the forces of high-power metas, let alone defeat them, but the existence of people like Xelas, Tyranny, and Doctor Mechanical proved it was possible. She just had to find a way through.

A particularly high leap brought her down near a seated Kyle, who jumped at the sight. “Gah! You know that’s terrifying, right?”

“Maybe I like being terrifying.” Trotting over, she plopped down onto the grass next to him. “You all right? I know not getting to talk with Ike sucks, but please tell me you understood going in that it was a longshot.”

“Trust me. I knew not to get my hopes up. Professor Quantum has gone off on the unreliability of magic more times than I can count.”

Plucking a few strands of brittle grass off the ground, he dropped them one by one, watching each flutter down. “What gets me is that I was useless *again*. I keep telling myself that it was a fluke, that we were against someone with powers that totally outclassed us. But tonight, we faced a totally different kind of challenge, and I whiffed it again.”

“It was a pretty tough combo to overcome,” Tori pointed out.

“But it *was* overcome, that’s the thing.” With some effort, Kyle raised his head, meeting Tori’s eyes. “Ike was rated as the weakest member of our team, and by a fair margin. And you, Tori, you don’t even do this kind of work or have powers. I’m supposed to be among the upper echelon of metas. Even without the suit, there are few who can beat my speed, yet

more and more it feels like this power got wasted on me. Like it should be in the hands of someone who can find these solutions that I always seem to miss.”

Tori was tempted to lightly smack him in the shoulder, but feared she might tear his arm off by accident. “Did it ever occur to you that maybe the reason Ike and I are better at finding non-conventional solutions is that we *weren’t* in the upper echelons-whatever shit you said? Let me ask you something: right now, sitting next to someone tapping into the powers of Fornax, how do you feel?”

“Seems like my embarrassing yelp earlier answered that one too well,” Kyle sighed. “Scared, of course. That much power in someone’s hands, it’s hard not to be a little afraid.”

“Yeah, well, *that’s* what it’s like for the rest of us without super-awesome-top-talent-whatever powers. We live every day knowing that some asshole that happenstance made a demigod can rip us apart, and while the capes might get justice, that doesn’t bring back our lost lives. So you learn to think on your feet, find unusual solutions, and never show fear. Without powers to lean on, all we’ve got is ourselves.”

“That’s a pretty good line. You should use it for a commercial.”

“No kidding around, I was literally thinking the exact same thing,” Tori agreed. Overhead, the sky turned to gray as the bat’s hands began to slow. In roughly five minutes, they’d burned away the rest of the evening.

Now, a new day would soon dawn. Fresh faces would enter wearing new costumes, some of whom would emerge with candy and trinkets, along with terrifying tales to carry with them. A handful would be forever changed by the experience, departing with gifts or curses that would alter the course of their lives irrevocably. And of course, there were those who would never emerge, guests who’d gambled their lives and lost.

Tori felt the strength fading from her limbs and wanted nothing more than to be done. Hallowville had been an entertaining adventure, but with Ike out of reach and Chloe’s task accomplished, Tori was more than ready to head home without a single break.

“Hey, on the drive back, does anyone want to grab breakfast?” Ellie asked. Around them, Hallowville vanished with the rising of the sun, the entire group finding itself outside the town’s limits once more. “I know a killer spot with all-you-can-eat French Toast.”

“Hell yes,” Tori called back immediately. After consulting with her stomach, she decided *one* break wouldn’t be so bad, especially if it involved an endless amount of food.

Together, the mix of capes and villains headed toward the parking lot, leaving the town of Hallowville behind, where it would sit, waiting, until they had need of its games again. Sooner or later, they’d come back.

After all, everyone needed a little magic from time to time. Especially, the dangerous kind.

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# THE PRIESTESS AND THE PERIL

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# I

Something was wrong. The formerly flickering sconces exploded in flame, hot tongues licking the stone ceiling, scorching wherever they lashed. Every holy symbol in the room was melting, along with most other metallic objects. One by one, the gorgeous, enchanted glass panes of the windows would crack, then shatter, despite all the magic poured into making them indestructible by generations of clergy who'd called this temple home.

Perle would have halted the ceremony under different circumstances. But then, she would never have needed to invoke the ancient rites were times not so desperate. Sweat coated her body, largely absorbed by the thick robes that offered excellent coverage and light protection from dangers, not that whatever was coming would be stopped by such minor magics.

This was a ritual from a tome hidden deep within the High Priest's personal room of the temple's library, one he'd no doubt planned on utilizing before his envoy was ambushed. With he and almost every high-ranking member of their local order killed or captured, it had taken no time for the neighboring towns to fall. Most of her fellow clergy were already on the run or in hiding, aware the fortifications of their home wouldn't hold off invaders for long. Only Perle remained to keep up the fight in any way she could, even if it meant digging into books marked "Dangerous" and "Forbidden."

Yet despite all the warnings she'd read, this didn't line up. Had she made some mistake in the summoning? The runes painted onto the floor were perfect—she'd checked them a dozen times—and Perle was adept with such detail-oriented work. Her incantation had perhaps faltered in a

few places, but the words were spoken clear and true, so it shouldn't be the spell. The only other piece of the equation was a totem lying in the center of the summoning circle.

Looking at it still caused Perle's eyes to water. She was using the symbol of a great warrior, one noble and true, to summon someone of a similar ilk. The sword still lay on the ground, magical energy crackling along the stained blade, reaching out beyond the limits of their world to find a worthy candidate. Obtaining her uncle's blade had been no small feat, not after those monsters took his head and mounted both for the whole town to see. It wasn't fair. Fesver was aged well past his prime; he'd have been able to handle them in proper fighting shape. But fair didn't matter. Fesver was dead, along with the hope of his city, their kingdom, and possibly the entire world.

So Perle didn't turn away, even as the sword rose into the air. She had to see this through. It was the only chance for those who survived. This had to work, because Perle wasn't sure what to do with herself if it didn't.

Something strange was happening with the blade, she realized. The magic was no longer running through the enchanted steel; it was congregating on the stain. One dark splash on an otherwise spotless sword. Fesver would never tell her about the cause, only that he considered it a source of great pride. Whatever it was, the magic had found its target, all of the energy streaming into that stain, lifting it from the metal, which clattered to the ground, forgotten. Now the dark material was glowing, a red hue that was much too familiar thanks to these last few months. There was no question to it: Perle was looking at blood.

Without warning, a blast of energy tore forth from the circle, extinguishing the flaming sconces and plunging the room into darkness. Only a few trails of light from the now exposed stars filtered through, casting their light on the smoking circle. Movement startled Perle into a soft squeak, and the figure jerked its head in her direction.

"B-b-by the Rites of Axcallion and the Order of the Lost Moon, I, Acolyte Perle, h-have summoned you, mighty champion, to aid in our most dire time of need."

The figure looked around the room, taking in its surroundings, every movement steady and deliberate. When he spoke, voice calm and deep, chills ran down her spine. She wasn't sure how most of the summoned champions had reacted, but something felt... off.

“This shouldn’t be possible.” His eyes continued to sweep the area, until they landed on the blade that had fallen away mid-ceremony.

“Fear not, noble one, for in our world, magic is a fundamental force, one that can— what are you doing?”

He’d leaned down and plucked the blade from the ground, turning it in his hands. “I know this sword.”

There was no warning, not so much as a sharp look in her direction. One moment, he was in the circle; the next, he’d nearly closed the gap between them. Perle squeaked once more, yet held her ground. With the smoke cleared, he didn’t seem quite so scary. Granted, the harsh expression on his youthful face was far from inviting, and the muscles did add to his threatening aura, but Perle had met with other trained warriors in the past. Compared to what her uncle’s town was facing, this was a manageable amount of fear.

“Where is the man who owns this blade?” He stared down at her, and Perle felt her resolve flicker. There was something to him, more than just appearances. This man radiated power in a way she’d never experienced before. Every step, every motion, carried with it an inherent sense of being unstoppable. Scary as that fact was, it was also heartening. She needed unstoppable right now, even if it came from someone a bit unnerving.

Fortunately, the truth served her needs well, especially if this man had history with her uncle. “Fesver is dead. Slain by the demons I summoned you here to stop.”

That provoked a small shadow of surprise in the man’s expression. “If Fesver is dead, then these foes must be quite strong indeed.”

“I don’t know how you knew my uncle, but since you are from another world, perhaps time flows differently between our realms. Age had stolen most of Fesver’s might, but he still took out dozens of their troops before... before their commander came...” She couldn’t relive it again, that huge club smashed into the ground, cackles of laughter from the monsters surrounding her uncle’s broken, crushed body before his head was cut free.

“Interesting. Ordinarily, my answer would be a flat no to whatever it is you want, but Fesver’s death complicates matters.” For a moment, the man seemed lost in the past, recalling scenes Perle wasn’t permitted to share. “I owed him one.”

From several floors below, a loud crash broke the peace of their conversation—sounds of the front gate being smashed open. Were she not

an acolyte, Perle would have cursed under her breath. Not now! She'd finally procured a chance, a piece of hope for all those who'd already lost it. But he'd just arrived, and had nothing more than the dark clothes on his back. There hadn't even been time for his newly gifted abilities to manifest. No weapons aside from Fesver's sword, no wands or staves, not even a few scraps of armor. If he died here, unprepared and caught off guard, then she hadn't any ideas left. So, he just couldn't die. It was as simple as that.

"Come on," she urged, grabbing for his hand and grasping only air as he pulled it free. "We have to run! The demon's troops are ransacking this place; if they find us, we'll be butchered on the spot."

"Perfect. That should make finding this commander's location much easier." He handed her back Fesver's sword, still unshaken, despite the thundering sounds of footsteps below. Had they seen the magic explode and come prepared for a fight? It sounded like there were several dozen foot soldiers, to say nothing of any demons that might be in their midst. Yet her champion only shook his hands and did a few small stretches. "Tell me about these enemies. You keep saying demon: is that colorful language, or accurate?"

"Accurate," Perle responded. She was out of options. Fleeing without him would do no good. If he was used to unarmed combat, however, then they might not be entirely sunk. A few peons could be beaten, and once he cleared out a path they'd make their escape. "Though not all appear monstrous, the demons are relentless, conquering one city after another, even toppling whole kingdoms. Usually, they are few in number but great in power, yet this time, it's been different. Such numbers have appeared, made worse by many of our own beaten forces turning traitor, offering to serve what they saw as the inevitable victors."

He frowned, turning toward the room's entrance, where the racket of stomping metal boots was nearly on top of them. "Fodder. I detest fodder."

"These are still skilled soldiers," Perle cautioned. "They were beaten by the strength of demons, that doesn't mean they can be taken lightly by mere mortals."

The boom of the great ceremonial chamber doors being casually slammed open sickened and frightened Perle, though not as much as the gleaming battalion that stepped through them. All hope of escape perished; this was no rabble. The demon had sent some of his stronger human troops; evidently, her theft of Fesver's sword had pricked at his pride. This was a

force meant not to win, but to slaughter, and send a message with the wreckage in their path.

“Well, well, Fesver’s little rat is still making trouble. Who’s this fellow? Did you cobble together some scraps of stolen sorcery to try and call forth a champion?” The leader of this unit was a tall man who carried a polearm, disdain evident on his face. “Tell you what, stranger. I have no idea what land she called you from, but this is not your fight, as you must already know. Kill the girl, and leave here with no hard feelings, free to make your way home and await the demon tide.”

The summoned warrior looked not at the speaking captain, but over to Perle, paying the newly arrived threat no mind. “Here’s how this is going to work, kid: I’m killing whoever took out Fesver. If, when that is over, you still have the courage to ask for my help, we can talk. Until then, keep your eyes open and see exactly what it is you’ve called forth. Understand who you’re setting loose on this world.”

Unrestrained laughter came from the troops before them, clearly not concerned with this man’s implied threats. Their leader held up a hand, stopping them short. “If that’s how you feel, then on behalf of Commander Dezzolorth—”

Again, he crossed the divide in an instant, appearing before the speaking soldier and wrapping a hand around his face, ending the speech mid-threat. “I’m offering up a one-person position to whoever is willing to lead me directly to this Dezzolorth. Interested parties should speak up quickly, because everyone else is in for the same fate as whoever this asshole was.”

At the word *was*, he squeezed his hand. The explosion of brain, blood, and skull was instantaneous, spraying out onto the nearest other soldiers; one poor soul who’d had his mouth open got a chunk on the tongue.

A moment of shock hung between the crowd of armed men and their supposed easy target, just as the mist of their captain’s blood still lingered in the air. Before the first of them could rally their senses, the stranger was on to the next in line, striking what should have been an armored chest so hard the metal caved along with the bone. A single wet cough escaped from the collapsed torso as the corpse slid dully to the ground.

It was the second death that broke the spell, forcing each soldier to realize that this man had no intent on stopping. Most turned to run, only to find him suddenly there, blocking the route to escape. In an act of desperation, the soldier at the rear hurled down his sword and shield,

rendering himself unarmed. He fell to his knees, arms raised to show no threat remained. "I surrender!"

"Coward." With a single movement, the stranger jammed a foot against the kneeling soldier's sternum, driving him backward onto the ground, followed by a loud *crunch* as he stomped down his leg like a stake, skewering his target to the floor.

The next up was a younger soldier, blade barely larger than a dagger in his thin arms. "I'll take you to the commander. Let me be your guide."

Lifting his leg, the summoned champion kicked their friend's body from his heel, letting it smash against the stone wall. "All right, then. The job is yours. Assuming you can hold it. Anyone who runs, dies. I'll keep whoever is left standing."

Too late, the inexperienced young man realized his mistake. While there was a monster to his front, the men he'd just tried to leave to their grisly fates were at his rear. With certain death looming, they would grasp at any chance for survival. He spun around, nearly in time to see the handle of the axe spinning through the air, but nowhere near fast enough to avoid its sharp blade biting into his skull.

Perle stifled a yelp as her champion reappeared at her side; that talent of his was so impertinent, yet it was nothing compared to the horror of watching him fight. Even now, after he'd stepped away, the death continued. These were not strangers thrown together; these were boys from town, some even men her uncle had once trained. They were longtime friends, now turning weapons on one another upon seeing the deaths that awaited them. Because of the champion she summoned.

"Let this be done! The fight is clearly won. You have triumphed. Permit them to live on, and repent the error of their ways."

"Absolutely," he agreed. "Whichever one wins. I don't break my bargains."

She wanted to look away, yet dared not, for in her heart, she knew that this was her doing. "Please, show them mercy."

"Mercy?" He pointed to the weapons slicing between armor, carving into one another's flesh. "Those aren't tools of mercy, not used like they'd planned. Those people came in here to kill me—and you, as well. It doesn't matter if they ever had a chance or not, that was still their intent. If I were weaker, it would be us lying in pieces. Don't delude yourself into thinking otherwise. This is better than mercy. This is retribution."

Drawing herself up to full height, still coming up short against his considerable frame, Perle summoned every scrap of authority she could muster. "Listen here: I summoned a champion from another realm, a hero to defend our lands from seemingly impossible odds. *You* are that champion, and are bound to my service. Now let them free!"

The look that came from his eyes stopped every piece of Perle; even her heart feared to beat. She was sure, in that moment, that it was over. Her only comfort was in knowing that the spell would return this man upon her passing. Letting him loose on her world would be much too heavy a sin, especially before death. Then, as suddenly as it came, the look passed.

"You are very mistaken, and very fortunate." With a jerk of his head, he swiveled to the soldiers, worn down to only four. From the way one with a spear was tilting, it would soon be three. Satisfied, his attention returned to Perle. "Whatever magic you think you cast, you are wrong. I'm not a hero, and you hold no power to command me. Be thankful for that, because I would have torn your head from your body at the slightest hint of such power. I will *never* be chained again."

Perle's hands were shaking now. What in the darkest hells was going on? Had she made a mistake in the ceremony? Perhaps performed the wrong ritual entirely? Whoever this monster was, he didn't fight or act like any champion of legend she'd read tales of. Except... he *was* strong. Whatever else might have gone wrong, she had succeeded in summoning a powerful warrior.

The spear-wielder was down, and as a man with a sword managed to slice deeply on an already disarmed opponent, a burly fellow with a great axe came from behind and nearly took off his head. The injured man went next with little struggle, leaving only the decapitator standing. He turned to face Perle and her hero, waiting for judgment.

"Do you intend to serve, or was that a misguided attempt at killing the would-be betrayers?"

Dropping the axe, the last soldier lowered himself down on a single knee, eyes never quite leaving his potential attacker. "I will serve. My allegiance is not to Dezzolorth. It was to the captain he forced to surrender, and then devoured. His last command was for us to survive long enough to escape."

"Then you've made a wise bargain. Lead me to him. I'll let you scamper away, and you won't even have to worry about your old boss

coming to look for you.”

“From the bottom of my heart, I hope that to be true. But he is not a commander without strength to hold the title, and the armies of demons are already powerful. You may be in for a greater fight than you realize. With respect.” Now, finally, the man lowered his eyes.

A long, low moan of a sigh fell from the champion’s lips. “Don’t do that. Don’t you go getting my hopes up.” The stranger walked over to his hostage, kicking the man’s weapon up from the ground and offering the handle. “I’m going to call you Axe; may as well let you keep it. Might come in handy on the trek. How far to get there?”

“We would have to cross around the Forsaken Bog, so a week by foot. Five days if you can ride.”

“A week it is.” His attention turned back to Perle. “Here’s how it’s going to work, Priestess. Whatever mistake you made, I don’t care. Someone killed Fesver, and I owe him one, so I intend to deal with his murderer. You can’t stop me, and I mean that literally. When that’s done, when you see what it really means to ask for *my* help, I have a feeling you’ll want nothing more than to send me home.”

She was already casting her mind back to the rites so carefully memorized, trying to recall a contingency for dismissing the spell. It was likely buried deeper in the tome, on pages she hadn’t managed to tear out. Nevertheless, Perle hadn’t come this far to not fully consider her options. “And what if I still wish for your aid? There is more at stake than one city and my uncle’s death.”

Suddenly, he was next to her again, the stink of viscera near tangible as she realized blood was still slowly dripping from his hands. “If, after everything you see, you still have the stomach to sincerely make that request, then I will listen. But understand this, Priestess: right now, your soul is clean. You didn’t try to summon a killer, and even attempted to halt me. You never chose to let me loose. Once you know, if you ask again... it won’t be an accident that time.”

Fighting back her body’s desire to gag on the smell, she tilted her head up, meeting his eyes. “My name isn’t Priestess. It is Perle, Acolyte of the Lost Moon. I’m not a beaten enemy. *You* don’t decide what to call me.”

“All right, Perle. I’ll remember that.” He stepped back, looking to their still kneeling captive. “Axe, start stripping the bodies of their money and belongings. Sooner or later, we’ll need funds.”



This wasn't over yet. Perle refused to let it be. She reached out, grabbing him roughly by the arm. "What, pray tell, shall we call you? You seem displeased at being referred to as 'hero.'"

"Because it's the wrong word. I've dealt with one of those, enough to know I'm far from it. As for names, I like to keep things simple." He paused, finally wiping away some of the gore from his limbs, even as Axe's hands grew sullied by the morbid collection. "Just call me Ivan."

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## 2

They walked in a loose formation, Axe at the front, loaded down with several bags stripped from his dead friends, Ivan at the rear, scanning around them like he expected a threat to come from any angle, and Perle trodding along in the middle, wondering what she'd unleashed onto the world.

In the hours since leaving the temple, or what remained of it after the destructive efforts of her ceremony and the soldiers storming through, little had been said. Occasionally, Ivan would ask a question about the terrain or area, which she or Axe would answer if they could. Never did he inquire about the demons, though, his upcoming foes that he *should* be learning about. Seeing his strength for herself, Perle understood the man's confidence, but he'd yet to try his might against a demon. If he took them lightly, the fight could end before Ivan realized the danger he was in.

As they started to veer left around a bend, Ivan halted Axe. "Hang on. Something's bothering me. When I had you point to the general direction of your captain, you pointed to the southeast. Yet we've been going northeast for a while, and now you're swinging us straight north. I hope you've got a good explanation for the detour."

Seeing Axe stiffen, Perle stepped in, truly worried that Ivan might kill their lone surviving soldier on suspicion alone. "He already told you at the outset, we're going around the Forsaken Bog. It spans for miles, so avoiding it takes a long detour."

"How much time would it take to cross if we didn't skip the bog?"

Somehow, she'd known deep down that the question was coming. A man who slaughtered armed soldiers and showed no fear of demons

wouldn't be scared off by a name alone. "I couldn't say for certain, because *no one* crosses the bog. My best guess is two to three days, based on the maps I've seen."

Ivan rubbed his chin, the dried blood on his hands flaking off at the action. "Fine, I'll bite. What's so scary about this bog? Poison, lights that lead you astray, magic vines that try to drag you under?"

"Monster." Axe whispered the word. If not for the stillness of the air around them, it might have been missed. They were close enough to the bog that animals were scarce; they didn't need words of warning to know it was dangerous. "There's a monster in the Forsaken Bog."

"I thought monsters weren't uncommon in your world? Fesver made it sound like the damn things rained from the sky," Ivan recalled.

"Please understand that my uncle was one of the strongest warriors of our world in his prime, and therefore, his sense of danger was somewhat skewed." Perle nodded to Axe, who stood stock still. "He has the right of it. What lives in the bog is unlike most monsters. It's something old and powerful."

"Allegedly." Ivan was looking southeast now, through the trees, toward the goal that awaited. "Sounds like you're both referencing rumors, meaning you haven't seen this monster in person."

While that might be technically true, Perle knew she had to nip this line of thinking in the bud, fast. "No, but I have seen the battalions of warriors who entered the bog in an effort to slay the beast and reclaim the land. I saw the priests weaving their blessings and the mages crafting spells of tremendous power. Three people made it back, all of them messengers. Do you know why it was only messengers?"

Surprisingly, Ivan nodded. "Because that unit should be made of their fastest runners, burdened down with the least amount of weight. You're saying that the only hope for surviving this monster of the bog is to outrun the other people it's trying to eat."

He stared southeast for a few moments more before making a decision. "We're changing up the marching order. I'm in front, Perle at my side, Axe ten paces back."

Already, Perle was building a head of steam for the fight. "We cannot —"

"I can, and I can drag you two along with me. That's why I'm taking the front. If the monster appears, let me handle it, and stay away from Axe."

That pulled her up short. “Why would I stay away from someone who can help defend us?”

That earned her a long stare from Ivan, ended with a deep sigh. “Deliver me from capes, and those like them. Axe, can you tell Perle here why I don’t want you to be close?”

“He’s worried I’ll kill you in the chaos,” Axe said, no pause for thought required.

Perle winced at the idea; weren’t they in this together now?

Seeing her reaction, Ivan shook his head. “You were really ready to trust him, weren’t you? Even after he came to kill us. Use that head of yours, Perle the Priestess. Assuming that soldier told the truth, if you die, I return home, making killing you the easiest way to take me out. That wouldn’t work long-term, I never forget a debt and have allies capable of crossing through just about any barrier, but you’d still be dead.”

Looking back to Axe, Ivan waved him to walk over. “Since we apparently know nothing about this monster, including how it attacks, there’s another reason I want you so far back. If it strikes from behind, you can call a warning without being in immediate danger.”

“As you command.” Axe was looking down at the worn trail from which they’d soon be departing. His steps were plodding, but constant. Scared as he clearly was of the Forsaken Bog, it didn’t rival his terror of Ivan.

After what they’d watched, Perle understood. The swamp was scary like a thunderstorm, whereas Ivan was scary like a growling wolf standing mere inches away. The storm was more powerful, but that didn’t mean they would happen to be struck by lightning. With the wolf, on the other hand, its attention was far more targeted.

“Stay close,” Ivan ordered, pointing to a spot at his side where he wanted her to walk. Perle thought about refusing, or fighting against the plan further, but deep down, part of her preened at the idea of arriving sooner. The faster they moved, the less time for Dezzolorth to realize he had an enemy approaching.

Ivan’s arrogance might well get them killed, but his strength was undeniable. She’d just have to hope Ivan was as powerful as he thought, otherwise their journey might prove to be a short one.



Their first day in the bog passed without incident, save for occasional smothered gags as they grew used to the smell. The Forsaken Bog was what Perle imagined it would look like if a giant scooped up a section of forest and ate it whole, then let the entire thing slowly dissolve inside their stomach. A sickly-sweet stink of rot and decay perfumed the landscape as they walked over withered roots and logs that turned to mush at a touch.

Even the ground was rotten; sometimes, a solid-looking step would give way and thrust a leg into the muddy water. By the time they found a slightly elevated area that was dry enough to rest for the night, Perle's boots and feet were both soaked through. There was no fire to build, thankfully, the air was warm—damp but warm.

There would be no shifts for watch, it seemed. Ivan told them both to sleep, and that was it. Using her robe as a makeshift pillow, Perle angled herself to stare at her summoned champion as she drifted off.

She was supposed to be the one leading. No... not even that was true. A more experienced priest was supposed to be the one who summoned the champion, somebody with skills and might of their own. Ivan was right: she was his obvious weak spot, which was why, normally, one as vulnerable as she would never have been chosen to conduct the ceremony.

Except the other temples had fallen too quickly. Before they realized the severity of the threat, the demons had attacked. It was their first strike of true war, hobbling their greatest enemy. Perle didn't believe her entire order had been wiped out; there were too many who traveled under the name of the Lost Moon to be so easily purged. But the damage was undeniable. Many of the greatest among their clergy were taken, some in their sleep as coin corrupted the promises of men, and the great temples burned.

Perle could still hear the fighting in the halls when she'd been suddenly awakened. Before that moment, the summoning was a childish dream she'd nurtured, favorite tales heard in youth that perhaps she'd taken too much to heart. The dying screams of fellow clergy filled Perle with the need to act, weak as she was. All she could think to do was save the sacred texts. From them, hope would spring anew.

By the time she arrived, the library was already in flames and blade-wielding forms swept the room, hunting for survivors. It took all her courage to find the book, but it was just too heavy. She couldn't escape lugging a fifty-pound tome the length of her forearm. With apologies to the souls of her order's librarians, Perle had torn out the pages she thought were

needed and escaped, intent on finding her uncle Fesver for protection while she worked out how to perform the ceremony.

Except she barely arrived in time to watch Fesver die. There was no one else to turn to, no one to look to for guidance. The town was taken over, and Perle had been forced to trek out to a temple that was more outpost than anything, despite its grandeur. Some curious bit of her wondered why such a lovely temple had been built near the edge of the Forsaken Bog, but there was no time for distractions with a ceremony to learn.

Now, at last, Perle had done it. She'd summoned her champion, and it seemed increasingly likely that he was going to get them all killed, perhaps causing quite a bit of havoc in the process. She bit back tears at the thought of yet another failure. Perle would not cry in front of this murderous man.

"You should sleep."

Ivan's words caught her by surprise; he hadn't even glanced in her direction, his head making the same steady sweep of their surroundings.

"I know." She really did. Exhaustion felt like it was radiating from her very bones. The spell she'd worked had taken a tremendous amount from her; it was hard to even see straight. When her eyes lost focus, Perle kept thinking she caught motes of light at the corners of her vision, only for them to vanish when she looked closely. "Ivan, what are you?"

This time, he did look over, something in his expression flickering for a moment. "Someone who honors their debts."

"Can you... can you at least tell me why you owe my uncle? Especially since your blood was on his sword."

The silence that met her question seemed to be the answer, until Ivan finally spoke once more. "We met in another realm, a place of constant challenge, where one puts their life on the line to gain the power they seek. I was... my strength was new, and I hadn't gained control yet. That's why I was there, in truth. Fesver was on a quest of his own, and we ended up aiding one another. He helped me both with mastering my own might and with realizing that I actually could still be hurt. It was good preparation for when I met—"

In a blur, Ivan was on his feet, staring out at the rippling waters around their tiny island of dryness. "Axe, quit pretending to sleep and get your weapon. Perle, make yourself low and small."

Slowly, Axe moved, rising to his feet like he was battling against gravity for every inch gained. Perle was already lying down, so she

bunched up, working to present a smaller target. It was somewhat humiliating, but the terror in her heart admitted that she'd rather be hunkered down than standing like Axe.

Ivan turned, this way and that, watching the ever-rippling water. Had it moved that much when they'd been walking through? Something had to be disturbing it; hopefully a smaller monster that could be easily dispatched.

A splash came from the left, and Perle jerked her head just time to see... nothing. There was nothing there besides a few extra ripples. Turning back, Perle understood her mistake. What she'd heard was a distraction, specifically meant to draw her attention. While she'd been looking to the left, from the water had silently risen a massive serpent. A pale cerulean hue wove along its scales, leading to a sizable mouth that was parted wide, revealing rows upon rows of teeth the size of daggers.

Despite its size, the serpent was quiet and quick, moving into striking position with only the few seconds its distraction had bought. Perle had no doubt that were she alone, she'd have never seen the killing blow. It would have come while her head was turned and taken her out in a single bite. All that saved her was the fact that Ivan stood between she and the monster, his eyes locked directly on it.

The serpent and Ivan were frozen like that, gazing at one another. It was Axe who broke the spell, letting out a ragged gasp and springing into action. She half expected him to drive forward, weapon held high overhead, swinging at the mighty monster despite their size difference.

Instead, Axe sprinted off into the bog at top speed, not even wasting the breath that would be needed to scream. He was probably hoping the pair distracted or murdered each other, giving him enough time to escape. Perle might have taken comfort in the fact that Axe hadn't tried to kill her before running, except he needed Ivan around to distract the serpent.

"Well?" Ivan took a step forward, watching the serpent's every move for a reaction.

There was no mistaking it, the serpent winced. The horrible monster that had devoured so many jerked back in fear at Ivan's approach. That alone might have been shocking to Perle, but the serpent wasn't finished. With aching slowness, the monster closed its mouth and lowered its head. Down to the ground of their island, with a slight tilt in its neck. Perle suddenly realized what was happening and felt the breath freeze in her lungs.

It was ludicrous. Perle knew her legends. She understood that the more powerful a monster was, the greater the chance it would be intelligent. As beings capable of rational thought and self-preservation, it wasn't at all uncommon for monsters to retreat when faced with life-endangering threats. Monsters that could reason were capable of many things, but in all the tales she'd heard and read, never once had the stories mentioned anything like this.

Monsters attacked or ran. They did not *bow*. But before her eyes, Perle was witnessing just such an event. The massive serpent had managed a rough approximation of a bow despite its physiology. Questions thundered through her mind, as many about Ivan as about what she was seeing. The only way such an act made any sense was if the monster not only believed itself to be outclassed, but also incapable of escape. Did this fearsome beast not think it could get away from Ivan, even on its own terrain?

The bow had shaken Perle, yet it had nothing on what followed. "Apologies to you, my now welcome intruder. I am rarely of my true mind and had no idea the strength of the prey that entered my domain. Yet the fear I felt for you has cowed my more savage instincts and given me a rare moment of clarity." Strange enough that the snake spoke, more curious was that it came with a rich tone and a refined air.

"Your home is yours to protect. I don't begrudge you checking on interlopers, but it's for the best you stopped when you did." Ivan still seemed unnervingly calm, as if the huge snake appearing and then supplicating itself before him was entirely as expected.

Slowly, the serpent lifted its head, being sure not to appear aggressive. "Should you command, I will leave you in peace, but this is an opportunity I have been waiting on for countless years. The bog we are in is not my home, as you said. It is my prison. I am caged here, a shell of my true self, with even my own mind often lost to me. However, one with strength such as yours could set me free."

It was possibly the first time Perle felt thankful she'd summoned *this* particular champion. A more traditional one would have been unable to resist the bait of adventure, an escapade where she presumed the serpent would turn on them at the first opportunity. Whereas Ivan had no care for anything aside from revenge for Fesver, and it seemed this monster wouldn't argue when he declined.

"How long would it take? I've got a demon to kill."



The serpent and Perle both stared at Ivan after that, surprised for entirely different reasons, though the former recovered first. “The place I need to take you is in the center of the bog, the direction you were already heading. I can also smooth out the journey to get us there more quickly, offsetting any time lost. Once we arrive, I don’t expect it will take long for one such as yourself.”

After a few moments of thought, Ivan nodded. “Fine. I’ll come with you to the bog’s center. Just go kill the one who ran off a few minutes ago. I don’t want him making it out and sending word ahead of us.”

That hideous maw parted once more, displaying the rows of teeth. It was odd that it spoke without moving its lips, but it was equally strange for a giant, bog-dwelling serpent to talk at all, so Perle paid the detail little mind. Her brain was already busy picturing the horrors that awaited Axe once this monster caught up.

“Here I feared I’d face my freedom on an empty stomach.” Without another sound, the serpent slid below the water, vanishing entirely.

No longer staring down two monsters, Perle managed to speak to the one she knew by name. “You aren’t actually going to set it free, are you?”

“Not sure. Depends on what the task demands. Either way, sounds like we’ll make much better time through at least half the bog.”

“And if you do set that creature free, and it goes on a rampage and destroys a town?” Perle demanded.

“Then somebody should kill it, instead of burying it away in a dark hole.” It was the first time Perle had seen Ivan’s calm truly fracture, and she recoiled at the fury boiling off him. The hatred and anger ran deep, and even as he regained control of his expression, she could still see it there, burning quietly.

He looked away, yet she had no doubt his next words were for her all the same.

“I *hate* cages.”

### 3

With the serpent guiding them, Perle and Ivan made much better time through the bog. Part of her held on to the hope that Axe would escape and use the opportunity to repent. However, those hopes were steadily dashed as the snake hacked up occasional hunks of familiar armor. While Ivan was steadfast and silent as usual, the snake turned out to be rather loquacious, telling its story as they tromped over the foul waters.

“Once, I was so much more than what you see before you. My splendor was undeniable, and such strength at my command. Through cunning and care, I’d risen up, gathering more power steadily, rather than the greedy louts who try to do everything all at once. Having reached the point of a demigod, with true ascension looming, I thought my success was inevitable... until the Valeon arrived.”

Perle’s eyes widened, whereas Ivan had no reaction whatsoever. Realizing he might not be familiar with the word, she interrupted to explain. “Valeon is a title bestowed on an incredibly powerful warrior, one who is blessed by the magic of light. It comes from the name of the first champion ever summoned. Whoever carries the title of Valeon is said to be undefeatable. Only time and age have ever bested them.”

“I know.”

“How do you—”

“He might have cooled off about it as he got older, but when I knew Fesver, he was upfront about his goal to claim that title for himself,” Ivan replied.

The words brought Perle to a halt, though she forced herself to pick up the pace once more when it was clear that neither Ivan nor the serpent were

planning to wait. “Fesver’s magical attunement was to the element of wind. To receive the blessing of light, you need its attunement first. He couldn’t have been the Valeon.”

To that, Ivan merely shrugged. “He was a determined guy. I liked that about him.”

When silence fell between them, save for the soft sloshing of waves, the serpent continued. “The one I faced lived centuries ago, and he was mighty indeed. We fought for hours, but in the end, I was no match. Tearing my heart from my body, he sliced it into four pieces. The first, he buried under what was once a serene meadow, binding me here. With most of my power taken, I’m little more than a mindless monster, only occasionally returning to my true senses.”

“Monster” was certainly an apt word. Perle’s eyes traced along the huge serpent gliding through the bog at their side. Were she traveling with anyone else, they’d all have been eaten, joining Axe in its stomach. Terrifying as the creature was, that only made its subservience to Ivan all the more curious.

“What will you require from me, specifically?” Ivan asked.

The serpent slid lower in the water, better able to meet Ivan’s gaze as it answered. “Beneath a gnarwood tree in the center of the bog is where my heart resides. Digging it out would be an undertaking for anyone, but that won’t be all. The magic of my prison makes me my own warden. There is a reason I act so aggressively in my mindless state; I’m driven to kill any who might even inadvertently set me free. While a combination of self-preservation and instinctual fear shook me loose, it will inevitably wane. Should you approach the tree, compulsion will overtake terror, and I will be forced to try and drive you back.”

This thing was going to attack? Perle felt her pulse steadily rising, whereas Ivan merely stared back at the serpent before nodding. “Warning me was smart. I won’t hold what you can’t control against you. Anything else?”

“There is the matter of removing a huge tree with deep roots,” the serpent reminded him.

“Oh, I’ve already got a plan for that.”



They only stopped once over the next several hours, pausing long enough for Perle to get some actual sleep. After her earlier failed attempt had resulted in awakening to a monster attack, she thought rest would forever remain out of her grip, but a few more hours of walking had debunked that notion fully. When she finally lay down, Perle was out instantly, so exhausted that she was spared a single dream. The way things were going, she was sure they'd have all been nightmares.

At last, twisted gray limbs began to appear in the distance, the gnarwood tree coming into view. It was vast indeed, at least ten feet from one edge of the trunk to its opposite, with hundreds of sharp, twisting branches poking out in all directions. The myriad of holes and warped bark made it look like a tree grown out of driftwood.

More concerning than the tree itself was their guide. As they drew closer, the serpent's chatter had dropped off. Now, it appeared to be twitching, jerking its head from side to side without warning, eyes rolling to stare at her and Ivan. Finally, when they reached a small embankment, Ivan stopped.

"Perle, you need to stay here. It's too dangerous to follow, and protecting you would slow me down."

Her sense of duty demanded she refuse, but one look at the wild-eyed serpent was all it took for her sense of self-preservation to shut that shit *down*. And as Perle reminded herself, she was functionally Ivan's weakest spot. Until Dezzolorth was slain, her duty was survival, ensuring that Ivan could bring Fesver's killer to justice. After that... well, she'd think of something, just like she had with the summoning.

Ivan and the serpent started forward, Perle making no move to follow. Instead, she sat down, watching carefully. The battle would show her what this champion was capable of far more than the first group of guards had. Normal humans clearly weren't a challenge to Ivan, though he'd also yet to fight anyone capable of wielding magic. The serpent was a physical threat that should be more on par with him. Even if he was stronger, fighting back such a monster wouldn't be an easy task.

Not that he seemed concerned, walking through the bog's muddy waters, drawing steadily closer to the tree. For a moment, it was an oddly serene image, man and serpent casting their small ripples through the still water. The tranquility was shattered, however, when the serpent suddenly attacked.

Perle saw no signs of warning. It came in a flash; a wide mouth was lunging for Ivan, intent on tearing off as much as it could swallow. Quick as the beast had been, there was still a fist waiting for it. With a casual backhand, Ivan smacked the serpent on the snout, sending it flying up out of the water and back a considerable distance.

The typically graceful serpent landed with an ugly splash, thrashing back up without a moment's hesitation. At this new angle, Perle could see its eyes, bulging and unfocused. A shiver went across her spine as she imagined what it would be like to live trapped within one's own mind, their body forced to betray them. She still wasn't certain that freeing this beast was wise, not that Ivan had once asked her opinion on the matter, but the more she saw of its imprisonment, the greater her empathy grew.

While Perle had been speculating, the serpent moved, slithering across the bog at incredible speeds. It wasted no time on stealth, instead racing toward Ivan as fast as possible. The two clashed only a short distance in front of the gnarwood tree, the serpent attacking more carefully this time.

It slapped at Ivan with its huge tail, trying to knock him off balance so its fangs could find an opening. Huge swells of foul water broke against the tree, sending disgusting spray into the air and making the whole area smell even worse. The increased waves helped obfuscate the serpent's tail, adding to its chances of landing a surprise blow.

Due to the churning water, Perle could no longer see Ivan, but if attacks were still flying, that meant he had to be alive, right? Looking at the mad eyes of the creature whipping its body about with abandon, her certainty wavered. Maybe it was just smashing his corpse to pieces before coming back to gobble her down.

For a fleeting moment, Perle reached into herself, touching her connection to magic. Flecks of light started to form around her fingers before she let them dissipate. Any attack she might manage wouldn't even annoy something that powerful, and her healing couldn't reach over such a distance. The briefly glowing fingers formed together into a fist. Yet again, there was nothing she could do. It was her world Ivan was aiding, her uncle he'd agreed to avenge, but the most Perle could manage was to stay out of the way.

A sudden halt of movement broke Perle from her thoughts: the serpent's tail was locked in place. As the waters settled, they revealed an unharmed Ivan standing calmly, the enormous tail held in place by the grip of one

hand. It tried to jerk back—an act that *should* have worked, regardless of Ivan’s strength. Between the size difference and his lack of stable footing, it wasn’t even a contest. Except Ivan remained unmoving, and the serpent only hurt itself by pulling on its tail.

“For your own sake, I’m going to need some room to work.” Whipping the tail around, Ivan began to spin it, lifting the serpent up from the ground in the process. Faster and faster he moved his arm, building momentum, and leaving Perle steadily more shocked.

This wasn’t crushing a human skull one-handed, a feat that many monsters and mages might manage; no, Ivan was heaving around an enormous beast with no visible effort. When he at last released, the serpent was sent flying through the air, hissing and snapping as it soared.

Ivan didn’t wait to watch it land, his interest set now on the gnarwood tree before him. Ever since declaring it existed, he’d declined to share details of his plan with either Perle or the serpent. Standing next to the massive flora, she truly had no idea what could be in store. Some sort of teleportation magic, or an ability to make it move on its own? There had to be a trick to it, whatever the notion.

As Ivan pulled back his arm and took aim, Perle realized what he was doing, to her own horror. There was no plan or trick at all. He was going to *punch* the cursed thing! By the gods, what sort of lunatic had she summoned? To think that a punch could actually—

The explosion sent Perle diving to the ground, peeking out from under the sleeves of her robe when swift death didn’t follow the tremendous noise. What greeted her was a sight out of a legend, and not necessarily the kind with a pleasant ending.

Ivan had indeed punched the tree, but it was more than that. Punches alone didn’t cause the things they hit to blast out in different directions, tearing itself and anything nearby to shreds. No wonder he’d left her back and hurled the serpent across the bog; they’d have been impaled by one of the numerous branches that had shot off and were now sticking out of the muck where they’d struck, some still quivering.

As for the tree itself, it was better described as a stump with a few small sections at the edge still standing. Ivan walked across the charred surface to the center, then knelt down and drove his hands effortlessly through the wood. In chunks, it came away, like nothing more than a pile of sea foam he was clearing aside to better see the tide pools.

Perle's whole body felt weak. Every time she started to feel at ease around Ivan, getting a sense of what he was capable of, those misconceptions were crushed as easily as the gnarwood tree. All of this, and he still seemed entirely unconcerned, even as the serpent appeared once more, careening toward Ivan at breakneck speed. Power like that... she knew it should be fear coursing through her, terror at what the world would suffer because of the man she'd summoned. But, to her shame as a priestess, it was not fear leaving her weak.

It was relief. The demons had seemed so deadly to Perle, and their captains all the more so. She knew they had tricks, magics, and cunning on top of physical might; Perle had feared her champion might be felled like so many who'd challenged them before. But with strength like that, it wouldn't matter. He could rip through the demons as easily as... as the humans he'd coldly slaughtered.

Bringing herself up short, Perle forced her mind to replay the actions of her champion when encountering the guards. He could have easily captured or subdued them, but instead had ensured that each one died, to a man. All that power was fine when pointed in the direction of the demons, it was on her to keep Ivan from letting it loose against humanity in the meanwhile.

By the time she composed herself, Ivan was pulling something up from his hole in the center of the trunk. It looked like a hunk of purple covered in slime, a spiky silver band wrapped around it. At sight of the object, the serpent seemed to lose all sense, hurling its entire body at Ivan like a giant club, trying to bash him flat.

All of it was for naught, however, because Ivan was standing at Perle's side, holding the hunk of meat. Up close, it was nauseating. The spines of the silver band were dug deep into the flesh, causing infected wounds that oozed and emitted a familiar stink. Was this thing the source of the Forsaken Bog's corruption?

"What's the deal with the band? And quickly, before it notices I'm gone."

"Oh... umm, it's enchanted, probably what keeps the serpent bound to this area." Looking closer, Perle filled her eyes with a soft glow, tapping into the aspect of light magic that offered insight. "No traps or safeguard I can see. Looks like whoever made this put all the power they could into containment. Before it looked like that, that chunk of meat must have had

some very potent magic. Besides, nothing made from caldium is going to break easily.”

All Ivan needed to hear were the words “no traps” and his hands were already moving. They wrapped around the silver band and pulled once. For a moment, nothing. Then the screaming of metal as it shredded apart, caldium’s reputation for durability be damned. Over at the tree, the serpent released a horrible yowl, a noise that turned to shrieks as Ivan yanked the spines out, tearing off the scar tissue that had grown around them.

“You’re hurting it!” Perle said, all memories of the attacks forgotten amidst the tortured screams echoing through the bog.

“Change usually hurts.” Ivan kept at it, pulling the spines out steadily, never letting up. “But if it gets you closer to where you want to be, then it’s worth the pain.” He yanked the last spine, pulling the silver band entirely free from the section of serpent heart. When it came out, the yells finally ceased.

Panting, the serpent lay on the remains of the gnarwood tree, eyes slowly regaining focus. Without warning, Ivan was there once more, kneeling next to the huge creature. To Perle’s shock, he laid a gentle hand on its brow, speaking soft words she couldn’t hear across the distance. Receiving his answer, Ivan moved over to the mouth, which pulled open to reveal those rows of enormous teeth. Unable to stop herself, Perle started forward through the muck. If it needed the touch of healing magic, *that* was something she could provide.

Showing no concern for the well-being of his arm, Ivan reached forward and set the hunk of heart down on the serpent’s tongue, then pulled his hand safely back before the mouth closed once more.

With a mighty gulp, the serpent swallowed. Seconds later, a cerulean shimmer wound its way along the creature’s scales, worming into the minor wounds suffered at Ivan’s surprisingly careful fists and mending them whole. The glow crept on, slowly covering every scale, until the entire creature was alight.

Like a soap bubble, the form popped, vanishing to reveal a thin, humanoid figure sitting a few feet from Ivan. Sloshing up to the edge of the tree, Perle climbed up just in time to watch as the figure snapped its fingers and summoned forth clothing. Dark blues and blacks formed the basis of its stylish outfit, which featured quite a bit of scale-theming. More impressive than the fashion was the magic itself; conjuration to that detail took some



skill, making it strange that the serpent hadn't shown an ounce of magic in its bout with Ivan.

Standing to full height, the figure bowed deeply to Ivan. "It has been so long since I felt my full mind in control, and there is much I need to sort out. Yet before all else, I must offer my thanks. You have saved me, and as such, I am in your debt. Whatever you need, only ask, and I shall provide."

"Nobody likes to carry a debt," Ivan said simply. "You can pay me back by helping us kill the demon captain we're after. That type always has fodder—a waste of time, but they can be annoying. Also, as you might have assumed from my reaction to Axe running off, if you try anything, I'll kill you where you stand."

"Or send a potential new ally to do it themselves." The serpent-like grin on its face might have left Perle feeling disturbed, if not for everything she'd been through since Ivan's arrival. "With my mind, I have also recovered something of my name. So, until our debt is settled, think of me as Auro, your ever faithful pet."

Taking along a magical serpent monster struck Perle as a fairly terrible idea; they had no knowledge on how trustworthy Auro even was. All they knew for sure was that it had been trapped by someone generally agreed to serve on the side of right. Although, seeing the way Auro had been bound, Perle had to wonder. The band didn't need those spines; that aspect had been added intentionally, a cruelty that went against the Lost Moon's teachings.

Ivan, on the other hand, nodded at the proposal. "Ally, not pet. When the task is done, we're square." Considering the matter settled, he started walking once more. Auro quickly followed, and Perle took up the rear.

With a now free serpent monster and the most violent champion she'd ever heard of leading the way, Perle headed back toward the realm of civilized society.

## 4

**I**t was a day later when a damp trio emerged from the last vestiges of the Forsaken Bog. In their traveling time, Auro had spoken at length about the area, his favorite hunting grounds, and of course, himself. Whether it was lack of conversational partners for untold years or just an amiable nature, the giant serpent in disguise was more than happy to go on at length. They'd learned that Auro was in fact male—though, as a shapechanger, that was entirely a matter of preference—that he hailed from a mountain nest, and that he'd been part of a clutch of dozens. Of those, only he and one sibling had survived. The rest were eaten... by those two.

Such was the way of nature, brutal and merciless, but never before had an aspect of nature conjured jaunty clothing and fashioned itself as her traveling companion. The whole idea would have left Perle entirely terrified, save only for the fact that Auro was a mewling kitten compared to Ivan. Even if it was at unnecessary length, at least the serpent in human skin *did* talk. Her summoned champion simply strode constantly forward, pausing only to allow Perle time for rest and sleep.

A flicker of motion caught the edge of Perle's eye, some shimmer of light that had been appearing just out of sight since bringing Ivan over. She had no more luck than usual in spotting it; however, the sudden swing of her head did bring a welcome sight into view. Some ways ahead, they were about to rejoin the proper road. Even better, Auro had led them out of the bog directly near a roadside inn. Once a staging ground for hopeful warriors preparing to march out and challenge the very monster at Perle's side, the building had been repurposed to accommodate weary travelers after challenges to the Forsaken Bog became less frequent.

“Ah, the Wallowing Sow. I don’t have many coherent memories from my time in the bog, but some of the people I ate spoke about this place while I was lurking. Supposedly, they serve some of the best ale on the road.”

“It’s midday. We don’t need to stop,” Ivan replied.

“These travelers also had exceptional lunches packed on them. I always considered eating Wallowing Sow patrons a treat when they brought their own side dishes.”

Perle expected another rebuffing, or her own stomach to groan. Magic allowed her to stem some needs, but eventually, hunger would always win. As if to prove the point, an audible growl rumbled around them. Except it wasn’t Perle’s stomach that betrayed her.

It was Ivan’s.

“I suppose we have been going for a few days. Perle probably needs to eat.” He made no mention of the noise, nor did Perle or Auro, though the latter did shoot her a conspiratorial glance.

As they drew closer to the road, and a sweet taste of civilization, Auro’s hands danced gracefully through the air. A warm wind washed over all three, and Perle felt her damp clothes shedding their excess water weight. Ivan stopped stock still at the shift, suddenly giving Auro a dangerous gaze. “What are you doing?”

“Making us presentable for polite company. One gets only a single chance at a first impression. Can’t have us walking in looking like drowned mucklurkers.”

“It’s dangerous to surprise me, especially with magic.”

A big, snake-like grin appeared as Auro bowed. “Sincerest apologies. I shall adjust my behavior accordingly.”

As they talked, the spell had finished its work. Perle was no longer soaked with swamp water—or her own sweat, for that matter. Whatever magic had been used, it was more than just a drying effect. Perle felt cleansed; even her nose agreed that the three of them had taken a sharp improvement. Purifying and clothing creation were not spells she would have expected from a giant serpent monster, though they certainly did help Auro masquerade as human.

Now tidy, the three figures finally stepped onto the road once more, having shaved a considerable amount of time off their trip. Moving steadily, Ivan reached and breached the front door in one motion, yanking it open

and striding right through. Perle and Auro were on his heels, walking into a surprisingly busy tavern on the bottom floor.

Around a dozen men were seated in a corner, multiple tables having been pulled together. They wore mismatched armor and weapons, nothing like the uniform gear of soldiers, such as the ones Ivan had slaughtered. A well-dressed fellow sat a few tables over, checked on constantly by glances from the crowd. Other than that, only a few more solitary forms hung about, along with a barkeep displaying broad shoulders and a red eyepatch.

“Perle, would you be so kind as to show Ivan to a table? As he is unfamiliar with our native cuisine, I shall take care of ordering our meal. Any preferences?”

“Anything is fine,” she replied.

Ivan nodded. “Just get plenty. If we’re stopping to eat anyway, may as well fill ourselves up.”

“Have no fear, I too am feeling famished.” There was a worrying glint in Auro’s eyes at that statement, but he was gone toward the bar before she could ask anything further.

Leading Ivan away from the rowdy crowd, Perle walked him to a smaller table on the opposite side of the room, sitting down across from the unstoppable force she’d brought into their world. With a moment to rest, she truly examined her champion.

In moments like these, he was downright unassuming. Simple, dark clothing. Features that seemed sturdy, more than handsome. A body of lean muscle that belied his true strength. Eyes appearing unfocused, as if his mind were near empty. It was when Ivan moved that the illusion shattered; Perle could sense the magic rippling at his every motion. What source did he draw from, to handle power like that? And how had it not torn his body apart from the inside out?

The sounds of footsteps drawing near pulled Perle from her prolonged stare. Assuming it was Auro returning, Perle put on her best polite smile. Until Dezzolorth was dead, they were traveling companions, and the least she owed someone in that role was civility. If it also made her less appetizing in the serpent’s eyes, all the better.

Her smile faltered at the sight of a tall man with dark hair sidling up to their table. There was an undeniable predatory tinge to his wide grin and beady eyes. “My, my, what fortune to meet fellow travelers on the road, and a priestess of the Lost Moon at that.”

Blood drained from her face as Perle realized she was indeed still clad in her formal robes, freshly cleaned and easily identifiable thanks to Auro. In all the chaos of summoning Ivan and the days that followed, she'd entirely forgotten that people were out hunting for her.

"As a devout man myself, there is a clear duty to provide aid through these dangerous lands. Although my compatriots and I are currently on a job, we'd be more than happy to offer you safe passage, as well. Please, come join our revelry."

Checking their surroundings, Perle noticed the rest of the large group was still laughing and talking, all while keeping an eye on the man standing by her table. Auro was speaking to the barkeep, evidently unconcerned with anything else going on. The only detail that stood out to her was that one of the men had moved to a new drinking spot: directly next to the door.

Whether Ivan had no notice of such details or simply no care for them, he barely bothered to glance at the man before speaking. "Not in the mood. Leave."

"Pardon me, good sir, but I was speaking with the priestess. If you feel the need to interrupt, then perhaps my dagger can instruct you in the finer points of ma—AAAAA!"

If Perle hadn't been looking directly at the two men, she wouldn't have seen it, the movement happened so fast. With incredible speed and dexterity, Ivan grabbed hold of the man's jaw mid-word, tearing it from his face in a spray of viscera. The scream that burst forth was short-lived, as was its speaker. Never slowing, Ivan jammed the broken jawbone into the man's left eye, driving it up into his skull.

Before his head bounded off the rough stone floor, the man was already dead, killed so quickly that no one had even found a chance to react, let alone offer aid. Rising from his seat, Ivan stared down the remainder of the group.

"Since he was so fond of instruction, listen well. If you threaten my life, I will take it as genuine, and make sure you never get the chance to try. Don't waste your breath talking about killing. Either strike or cower. Die or survive. It's all the same." With a well-aimed kick, Ivan put a foot under the body and sent it flying out the front door, skull clipping the edge and leaving a dark stain on the way out. "You're all the same. Nothing but fodder."

Droplets of blood were soaking into the wooden table, domes of liquid transforming into dull red stains. That was all that would remain of the man who'd been alive until moments prior. Even if he had been seeking her capture, Perle couldn't believe the casual ease with which Ivan had ended a life. That, more than his raw power, was what terrified her. Death flowed from him naturally, and he wielded it without hesitation.

"You really think you can kill our friend and get away with just a scary little speech?" The speaker was dirty-blond, with a few upper teeth missing. "Quick as you might be, you can't take all of us."

"I could slaughter your ilk from dusk until dawn and only stop because of boredom." To Perle's utter shock, Ivan retook his seat across from her, as if there wasn't a gang of people audibly rising from their chairs and readying weapons. "But I'm only here for a meal. So, as I told your friend: leave. If you don't, then there's no one to blame but yourselves for what comes next." Ivan spoke the last of his sentence while staring directly at Perle.

He'd given them a chance to escape. Granted, he'd done so while antagonizing them in the process, but Ivan could have murdered everyone instead. Was this him attempting a compromise, or drawing attention to the way he handled such encounters?

Whatever the cause, no one in the crowd seemed to realize the gift they'd been handed. More and more of the ruffians rose, adjusting their armor and unsheathing weapons. Only the well-dressed fellow sitting a good distance off remained seated, swiveling slightly to gain a better view. His eyes glistened with concern over the impending bout, but he had no idea the brutal show he was actually in for.

Just as the crowd began to advance on Ivan, a loud cough came from behind them. Having finished his business with the bartender, Auro had silently shifted positions, somehow slipping around—a great deal of effort spent on stealth, only to announce his own presence so loudly. Still, it worked, turning every head in Auro's direction, even Ivan's.

"As I am new in this role and endeavor to do an acceptable job, permit me to check before acting. This would be the type of enemy you had in mind for me, correct? The fodder, as you called them."

"That they are," Ivan agreed. Meeting Auro's gaze, Ivan nodded, giving permission to press on.

Sadly, the dirty-blond ruffian wasn't content to watch the quiet dialogue, advancing on Ivan with a hatchet drawn. Before he could strike, a sudden yelp rang out from the rear. The would-be attacker's movement had pulled Perle's attention to him, along with most of the other eyes in the room. At the noise, her gaze darted over briefly, expecting to see Auro punching or casting a spell on one of the men in the back of the crowd.

Instead, she could only stare, transfixed in horror, as the pair of still kicking legs vanished into that oversized maw. Although still at human size, Auro was demonstrating just how fluid his form really was. The entire front half of his chest, from mouth to waist, had wrenched itself open into a gaping maw filled with sharp teeth. With an audible *gulp*, the legs vanished, as did any hint of the person who'd once used them.

Most of the crowd was staring on with the same shock as Perle, and that cost the nearest one to Auro dearly. He surged forward, snapping that horrible mouth down and snaring the stunned man's arm. Unwilling to die so easily, the man in shoddy armor grabbed hold of a nearby beam, pulling with all his might to not be dragged in by those jaws. Auro proved unwilling to engage in a prolonged standoff, which would have left him vulnerable to the others in the group. A mighty flex of that unnatural mouth was all it took to rip the arm cleanly off, where it vanished in another loud swallow.

The now one-armed guard was staring at his stump, trying to process the sudden injury as blood flowed steadily onto the ground. Moving on instinct, Perle felt herself start to rise. A wound of that nature required swift treatment if there was any hope of survival. Yet as Perle watched Auro spin around to greet another attacker, long tongue flicking out and tripping their feet so the serpent could pounce, she was struck by an unfortunate truth.

None of these men had any hope of survival. Maybe they would have really taken her by force, tossing her at the feet of a demon hunting her head. Or perhaps they were only talking tough, trying to look impressive in front of their employer. This world could be a hard one, even more so since the war came, and it forced its people to make difficult choices. Whatever they were, or had been, or could have become, it was all irrelevant; they were going to die, and it was because of Perle.

Even as Auro snapped his jaws down, neatly bisecting a man scrambling to raise his crossbow, Perle felt the blood stain her own hands. Ivan said it wasn't her fault because she hadn't known what she summoned,

but the priestess didn't take such a simplistic view on morality. She'd known the summoning was a risk, had been fully aware that she didn't have the entire tome, was prepared for the possibility of something to go wrong. And while it had, undeniably, turned out unexpectedly, the situation was still workable. Her champion was, if nothing else, powerful.

But he was also the kind of man who freed a human-eating monster and then turned it loose on a tavern full of people. Perle winced in empathy as one of the men managed to score a hit on Auro, their collective desire to survive overpowering their terror. The knife skittered along his skin, unable to pierce, before one of Auro's own hands gracefully snapped the man's wrist. All attention was entirely on Auro, she and Ivan forgotten as the gang fought futilely.

Perle knew she was partly culpable for the slaughter now unfolding. Even setting aside how her actions had brought Ivan forth and freed Auro, Ivan only existed in their world for so long as Perle lived. If she were truly repentant, sincere about removing this man and the danger he represented, then she knew the way to send him back. Her ethics redeemed, at the cost of her world's greatest hope.

Going into the ceremony, Perle had thought she was willing to sacrifice anything, simply because she was prepared to die if needed. Now, she was learning that some costs were far more insidious. Using Ivan's power meant walking the font of death through her world, accepting the toll of life that came with such a pilgrimage. It might not be her life that vengeance demanded, but her very soul.

That was why Perle forced herself to look on as Auro caught a sword mid-swing, twisting the steel into another opponent, one who'd been trying to sneak around his left side. She kept on staring as limbs, bodies, and various objects all went tumbling down that oversized mouth, never to be seen again. Her hands tightened along the knees of her robe, but Perle refused to let her neck turn away. She was part of this, allowing it to happen. It was her duty to bear witness.

The tavern's other patrons hadn't shared Perle's sense of obligation and scrambled out the door, some screaming as they ran. That poor soul who'd been stationed by the exit was half-crushed in the scramble, still putting him well ahead of all the others who'd faced off against Auro.

A handful of minutes, that was how long Auro required to entirely wipe out the force of fearsome men. And that was without magic, his giant body,



or taking the bout in any way seriously. Auro was cheerfully patting his belly as he surveyed the blood-soaked floor. Every now and then, he'd find a piece of flesh that had been missed and pop it into his mouth. Hungry eyes glided across the room, to the well-dressed man still in his seat.

Wild as Auro appeared, he'd only eaten the people who rose to attack her and Ivan. She wondered if that policy would hold. Eating so many must have taken the edge from his hunger, but Auro's true form was massive, and snakes could devour a great deal.

Raising a hand, the seated man waved to the barkeep. "Ethun, I shall cover whatever they ordered." Looking over to Ivan, the fellow bowed his head respectfully. "In exchange for refreshments, might I bend your ear about a dilemma in need of solving? I held no love for those brigands; however, they were contracted for a job, and I now find myself with well-paying positions to fill."

"We're previously engaged," Ivan replied, not a moment of consideration given.

"Very well. With strength like yours, it's clear there's no point in pushing." His eyes shifted to her, lingering on the symbols of the Lost Moon long enough that she feared he too had visions of turning her in.

"Only... you travel with a priestess, so please allow me to add one detail: this is a rescue mission. A knight was last seen in this area, searching for one from your order whom it was believed needed help. Unfortunately, the knight was captured by a small army of bandits who are attempting a ransom. As this knight has no noble backing, however, the gold they want won't be coming. If nothing is done, this will end with innocent bloodshed."

Although a bit more polite this time, Ivan still shook his head. "As I said, we are prev—"

"We'll do it," Perle interrupted. Her gaze had shifted from the well-dressed man to the sea of blood staining the floorboards, dwarfing the small droplets that lingered on her table earlier. It was her fault Ivan was here, her fault Auro was free, and her duty to put their power to proper use. Perle was never going to be able to stop them from killing, but she could make sure they pointed that deadly power in the right directions. Like saving someone who'd been out trying to help her.

When she finally looked back at Ivan, he was waiting. Their gazes met, his eyes piercing through her like he was searching for something.

Whatever it was, apparently Ivan found it, as his head slowly inched forward into a nod.

“Very well. Tell us about this knight.”

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# 5

According to Lelren, the well-dressed employer of the brigands, the knight in question had been combing the area, searching for a priestess of the Lost Moon. Upon hearing rumors of bandits nearby, the knight had investigated, suspecting they might have snatched up the priestess. That attempt at scouting ended in capture, with a ransom demand reaching the guard captain of the nearest outpost. Unfortunately, it seemed this knight wore no insignias indicating a patron and was refusing to talk, meaning no one had any idea what noble house would need to take care of such demands.

In the end, Lelren had put together a rescue mission out of obligation; apparently, the knight had taken a role in guarding his caravan during the trip down and had saved the merchant's life in the process. That was enough for Lelren to commission the band of brigands and set out in search of the lost knight.

As it turned out, however, that sense of duty wasn't quite enough to sway Lelren into continuing the journey with a human-eating monster he'd watched wipe out the majority of a tavern. After telling his story and handing over a reasonable sack of gold, the man had quickly excused himself and taken a swift leave, sweat dripping visibly from his forehead.

Perle didn't fault Lelren for his retreat. If anything, he was the sane one; running from such creatures made sense. The strange one was her, having a delicious meal with the pair after having witnessed brutal slaughter. But several days without food was enough to make her mind forget just about anything that might have otherwise turned her appetite, and before they were done, Perle had put down several platters of meat and greens, along

with an entire loaf of bread. It paled in comparison to the ridiculous amounts shoveled into both Ivan and Auro; however, for someone of her size, it felt like a tremendous meal.

With the food heavy in her stomach, Perle wanted nothing more than to inquire about a room, perhaps even a tub with warm water, and to fall asleep on top of a soft mattress, rather than damp swamp ground. Instead, she had to make do with leaning back in her comfortable chair.

Images swam in front of Perle's eyes, flickers of her parents dutifully minding the temple. The pain of standing in that same room, staring on in disbelief as an older priest explained that they'd been killed, lost in an unexpected monster attack while ministering to wounded civilians. Weeping under the sigil of the Lost Moon until she passed out. The intensity of Fesver's gaze as he promised vengeance for Perle's lost family and his own brother. The dark glee she'd felt at such a vow, even as the elder clergy chastised Fesver for such a notion. She'd never told anyone about that kernel of wicked joy, or how it had bloomed when Fesver returned, dragging the corpse of a tremendous monster. The pack that had swept away her parents had an alpha, one that Fesver left rotting in front of the temple.

An eyesore to the priests.

An unforgettable gesture of love to his niece.

Perle awoke in a panic, startled by the feel of arms under her back and legs, to say nothing of the dark sky overhead. Hadn't she just been in the tavern? Struggling to get free, Perle found the arms beneath her didn't so much as quiver, and she whipped her head around to face her captor. Ivan stared down, the barest hints of amusement twinkling in his eyes.

"Feeling rested?" He carefully set her upon the ground, and Perle spun about to check her surroundings. Night had fallen at some point while she slept, and there was no telling how far the pair had trekked while carrying her. At least they were deep in the forest, a setting whose greatest selling point was *not* being a foul swamp.

"I... I can't believe I fell asleep," Perle admitted, feeling a flush enter her cheeks and hating herself for it.

"I certainly can. We were pushing on for days there, and you barely got any rest. After a sudden shock and a big meal, it's no wonder your brain decided to shut down for a spell." It was an odd sensation, being warmly comforted by Auro, when her most recent memory was of him devouring an

entire gang. Yet the horrors he'd performed didn't make his words any less reassuring.

"I suppose so. At least I'm well rested for the work ahead." Pausing, Perle squinted, realizing she couldn't see very far since the trees were blocking a good deal of moonlight. Reaching into herself, Perle touched the magic that flowed through her, willing it to follow her commands. Since she carried the attunement of light, her task required only the barest bit of power, the world sharpening in clarity. A minor technique, barely even a spell, it allowed one to infuse light into their own vision. Perle had first learned the trick to sneak through the halls when she wanted a midnight snack.

Before she could speak again, Auro was on her, staring into her eyes with a ferocity that made her dart back, only for him to keep pace. "What's this now? You can cast? I thought the ambient spell trying to latch on was your big trick, but you're a fellow practitioner?"

Nodding, not fully comfortable opening her mouth with Auro so close, Perle once more tried to retreat. This time, Auro allowed her a couple of paces. "I have been trained in the ways of wielding since first discovering my attunement and its potency in youth."

"And what a strong one it is. I could sense the connection when your magic took hold." Auro sniffed, both the air and Perle directly, before finally stepping back himself. "Tell me, this instruction you received, would you consider it comprehensive?"

"There are as many ways to wield magic as there are stars in the sky. I would never presume to have touched even a portion of its full breadth. However, I was suitably trained for the duties expected of a priestess of the Lost Moon. My skills at mending are quite exceptional. I have spells that empower and shield, enchantments to soothe, and a small capacity for offense."

Ivan loudly tapped a tree trunk, leaving a small indent in the bark. "There's no one nearby, so I don't care if you two talk, just do it while we're moving." He started forward, clearly expecting that they would follow, which Perle and Auro did.

"What you have, my dear child, is a wildly misbuilt foundation of understanding," Auro said, not losing a step as he resumed their conversation. "You would never presume to have touched magic or what-not? Ridiculous! Magic is all about presumption, boldness, absolute

arrogance of will. Look over there, at that curved branch up ahead, is it whole?”

Following his eyes, Perle spotted the limb in question, jutting out from a large trunk and twisting round in a spiral. “Appears so to me.”

Less than a second later, a blade of blue light whipped from Auro’s hand, cleaving through the wood and sending the limb tumbling to the grass below. “Wrong. It’s cut into pieces, but not by any physical means. I didn’t pick up a sword or axe, didn’t walk over and swing my arm, yet the branch is cut. I imposed my version of reality over the prior one, forced the world to bend to my will, even if only in a very limited capacity. That’s what magic is, rebuking reality and imposing our own version of what should be. Magic adores presumption and arrogance, because it is itself a usurper.”

That was certainly a new interpretation of wielding magic. Perle had grown up with the unseen force being treated as sacred, whereas Auro spoke of magic like it was a pal he got into tavern fights with. Up ahead, Ivan paused for a moment, turning his head around.

“I should probably know this before we fight someone who can cast, how does magic work for you all? Fesver said that everyone had an attunement, but I’ve seen barely any magic used so far, even in life-or-death situations.”

Perle barely had time to open her mouth before Auro had launched into an excited explanation. “Oh yes, yes, everyone has an attunement, in the same way that everyone has bones and muscles. Doesn’t mean they can all hit like you, though, now does it? Attunements are the energy that our minds—or souls, in some interpretations—naturally connect with. Anything using that energy will come easier, take less out of the caster, and be more powerful. The other part of the equation is potency: how strong our connection to magic via that attunement is. Perle here, for example, has an exceptionally potent attunement to light.”

“Got it. So, capable casters are rare, but they’ll generally be limited to elemental spells,” Ivan surmised.

This time, Perle managed to answer first, determined to prove her own knowledge on the subject. “Certainly not. As Auro said, magic attuned to our element comes easier, but it’s not the only option. And spells can be far more than just a blast of light or fire. Energy is merely the starting point. More skillful mages can manage all manner of effects. I mean, you watched Auro form clothes out of nothing.”

“Not nothing,” Auro corrected. “Water. I currently have only my water attunement.”

“Only? One attunement is all anyone gets.”

To that, Auro merely smiled. Perle might have prodded the subject further, however Ivan held up a hand and motioned for them to stop. Peering back, he pointed at them, then the ground, and fixed both with a pointed stare. The message was obvious: stay here. As soon as he saw both standing still, Ivan dashed off into the woods, barely making a rustle.

It was unnerving, that he could move so smoothly. A man who hit that hard shouldn’t also be able to deftly slip up behind a victim unheard. Perle’s heart ached for whatever soul encountered Ivan under the dark forest’s branches. Not until almost a minute later did Perle realize that Ivan had left her alone with a person-eating monster who could gobble the priestess up in a single bite. She didn’t really expect Auro to try anything, but it was a bit galling after he’d been so quick to make her feel silly for trusting Axe.

Almost ten minutes later, Ivan returned. “I found a pair of guards keeping watch up ahead. We’re getting close to their camp.”

“And just where might these delicious sentries be found?” Auro inquired.

“Snack later. There should be a whole camp of these bandits when we get there.”

“What if we... didn’t kill them all?” Perle ventured, the words sounding thin and hollow even to her own ears. “Between the two of you, surely this knight could be rescued without unreserved slaughter.” She closed her eyes, unable to bear the dismissive weight of Ivan’s gaze mixed with Auro’s visible incredulity. “Even if they have strayed from the righteous path, they are still people. Sentient beings with the capacity for change and redemption. I understand death may be inevitable in our efforts of rescue, but I am the one who set us upon this path. I only ask that you please limit your killing to actual threats.”

A soft touch on her back offered an unexpected sense of comfort as Auro gently patted her between the shoulder blades. “No wonder you were able to summon such a strong champion. Perhaps it was fate that drove you from the church before its rot could infect such idealism.”

“What would you know of my faith?” Perle’s eyes snapped open, and she recoiled from the touch, even if it pained her slightly to do so. She’d

had so little comfort since the temple fell that even a kind pat from a monster was difficult to refuse.

“I know a great deal of faith, and even more of gods, little one. Do not forget that this is but an echo of my true might. My journey of ascension was nearing completion. But even more do I know people, the ones you think will turn to better ways when given the chance.” A slender, worrisome grin touched Auro’s lips. “Ivan, may I offer a suggestion?”

Ivan shrugged. “Say what you want. If it’s a good idea, we can talk.”

“With humble grace do I accept the opportunity. I would like to propose that we follow Perle’s advice when arriving at the camp. Let us restrain our deadly power and approach peacefully, offering a path of genuine escape to all who wish it.”

Perle shook her head. “I know they won’t believe you, not until it’s too late. Same as back at the tavern.”

“There are bound to be a few overly aggressive guards in such a place. One or two will overstep enough to make examples out of. A display of how futile it would be to fight back, on presumably deserving targets. Would that be amenable?”

“*If* we were attacked, then I suppose I couldn’t rightfully object to you defending yourselves,” Perle cautiously agreed. While it was a substantial stretch to call whatever Auro or Ivan would do “defense,” even clergy were permitted to fight back when under assault. The unfortunate souls who challenged her group would have made that choice themselves, and reaped the horrific consequences.

Auro clapped softly, careful not to make too much noise now that they were getting closer. “There we are then, a workable plan to offer most present an informed choice where they can freely escape my stomach. What say you, Ivan?”

He paused their trek, turning to actually meet Auro’s eyes. “Why?”

“Because I want Perle to see, with her own eyes, what choice they make. I want her to understand humanity the way I do. It may break her faith, or perhaps she will have the strength to love them still, faults and all. Through trial, we are broken or bettered. Sometimes, a little bit of both.”

To Perle’s surprise, Ivan’s interest next turned to her. “Why go along with this? You must know how he expects it to play out.”

“I do,” she admitted. “Besting him is not so difficult as it may appear. If any of them flee, even a single soul, then the day shall see one less death.



One soul, who may yet be turned toward a better life.”

“You think all that’s needed to prove your point is one person to run for their life when faced with a pair of monsters?” Auro didn’t make any attempts to hide the skepticism in his voice.

Sighing, Perle turned away from the still watching Ivan to face Auro. “No. What I’m saying is that playing your game gives me the chance to save that one soul, or even more. You think the bandits will make selfish, destructive choices even when given a path to freedom. And yes, it will wound me if that proves to be the case. But in accepting that wager, I am able to secure a path of escape for however many will take it. If you’re right, I’m forced to watch another slaughter that would have happened regardless, whereas if I’m right, lives are saved. That is a bargain I will happily take.”

While Auro’s features shifted across a myriad of potential emotions in response, Ivan merely snickered. “I see you take after Fesver in more than just the chin.”

Before Perle could fully process what she was fairly certain was a compliment, Ivan continued, addressing both she and Auro. “We’ll go ahead and try it Perle’s way, within limits. If it gets too dangerous for her, I’ll calm things down.”

“A responsible, if limiting, addendum. But whatever shall we do if the bandits should prove too dangerous for me?” The way Auro smiled, stretching the edges of his mouth like when he’d opened a maw encompassing his entire chest, left no questions as to how likely he considered such a scenario to be.

“If a group of random bandits can put you in peril, then either bandits are much deadlier here than in my world, or I was sold an incredibly false bill of goods regarding your strength. Either way, we’ll call the debt squared if you’re killed in the fight.”

“I will choose to interpret that as an encouraging show of confidence rather than a disregard for my well-being, though I do expect adequate mourning over my grave should I be felled by these ruffians,” Auro replied.

There was no verbal response from Ivan, who’d held up his hand to halt them once more. Again, he darted off ahead; however, this time, he was back in barely over a minute. “Caught signs of a trail, and it’s recently used. We’re close. Everyone quiet down until I step out into the open, at which point, Auro can do the talking.”

“Me?” Auro’s tongue flicked out of his mouth for a split second; evidently, it was a reaction when he got caught by surprise.

“I’m not much for chatting. You two have your wager; sort it out as best you can. So long as the situation stays controlled, I’ll hang back. If not...”

If not, people would die. Everyone in the camp, most likely, however many soon-to-be-corpses that encompassed. Some were bound to be only working as helpers, cooking meals and keeping the shelters whole, tending to the basics of a life outdoors. Perle knew many would be lost; she’d accepted that toll when she pledged her party to help the knight. But she could—*would* see that they were given a chance at salvation.

Steeling herself, Perle followed Ivan as he stepped silently through the night, her own movements a blundering chorus in comparison. At least when Auro darted around with nary a whisper, there was magic and unnatural coordination to blame. They walked parallel to the trail, keeping out of sight among the forest even if it made for slower going. Soon the sounds of voices reached her, along with the scent of a campfire, whose glow she could now see burning through the trees. In what felt like no time, they’d arrived, their movements concealed by the ruckus going on just past the trees.

With a prayer for wisdom and clarity whispered under her breath, Perle moved in harmony alongside Ivan and Auro, the trio stepping out into the open.

## 6

The shapes around the fire reacted instantly, shifting together into a tight formation, eyes examining the trespassers who'd so brazenly strolled into their camp. One section remained unmoving, however. Toward the back of the camp, a half-dozen bandits were standing around a wooden stake driven into the ground. Chained to it was a figure in dark armor, easy to miss in the gloom of the night. The prisoner seemed to have far better equipment than their captors, who were clad in mismatched pieces of leather, with only a few able to use actual metal. Why they hadn't stripped the knight's armor, Perle had no idea, nor was she offered time to speculate.

A thick-necked man who wore no armor or shirt stepped forward, hands dancing against the axes strapped to his waist. Bent teeth were revealed by his crooked smile, eyes centering on Perle with only cursory attention paid to Ivan and Auro. A predator's gaze, one she could feel as it washed over her. Days prior, the sensation would have put genuine fear into Perle, considering the brute doing the looking. Now, she could only wonder if this soul would find a better path in its next life.

"And who the hell might you—"

"Introducing the esteemed, amazing, undefeatable, unstoppable, Ivan." Auro's words were on his tongue and waiting; he'd clearly held back until there was a chance to interrupt whoever spoke up first. "And I, his humble hand, Auro, along with our priestess, Perle. Now, raise your voices in praise as you drop to your knees, for Ivan has agreed to spare those who surrender swiftly. Do not test this compassion, I urge you, for you shall find only gnashing teeth waiting if it's rejected."

For several long seconds, there was only silence and the crackle of wood popping in the fire. Then came the laughter, soft at first, growing in strength and depth, until the entire campsite was roaring with good humor, save for a chained figure in dark armor. The helm was pointed in their direction, however, so it seemed Auro had gained everyone's attention.

The shirtless man looming before them slapped his knee in laughter before wiping his eyes and pointing to Auro. "Tear out this one's tongue. Kill the other quick if he doesn't resist. I'll be taking the priestess."

Two bandits stepped forward instantly, hard stares above their cackling mouths, outstretched hands reaching for Auro. Before those limbs could be chomped off, a *crack* tore through the campsite, drawing all eyes back to the formerly chained knight. Splinters fell off the shattered haft of wood, from which the chains had been yanked free. With casual ease, the knight tore the links away like no more than errant strands of a spider's webbing, casting the metal to the ground.

Had Perle not watched Ivan punch a giant snake out of sight a day prior, she might have been more stunned by such a display, though the bandits clearly were taken aback.

"Are you the priestess of the Lost Moon?" The knight's voice was somewhat muffled by their helm, yet Perle heard it well enough to understand. She also saw Ivan moving to intervene, so roused her voice quickly.

"I am. Why do you seek me, good knight?"

One of the guards evidently realized they were not doing their duty and took a run at what was supposed to be their prisoner. A dull sword clanged off the knight's shoulder pauldron and chipped, leaving not a scratch behind on the armor. With one quick punch, the knight buried a gauntleted hand in the attacker's stomach, sending the man to the ground in a painful heap.

"I was sent your way by an oracle, with instructions to find you no matter what."

"That's enough!" The shirtless leader yelled loud enough to stun even the bugs buzzing through the air, fury rolling off him in visible waves. "Relash that prisoner! Grab me my priestess! And where's that tongue?"

Turning, he found the two men that had been standing near Auro were suddenly gone, only a mischievous smile on the slender man in blue who remained. From the knight's area, more sounds of combat bubbled forth. Most worryingly of all, Ivan took a visible step forward. Perle could feel the

situation slipping out of hand, the lives of everyone present seconds from becoming forfeit.

Holding up her hands, Perle stepped forward, purposely moving beyond Ivan's immediate grasp. "Everyone, please wait! I know these must sound like desperate pleas, but I beg you to listen. The next steps you take will be the most consequential of your life. The men beside me are not men at all. They are monsters wearing our shape. In the short time I've known both, there has already been so much blood. Any of you with loved ones, dreams, or a single hope for the future: run. Rethink your ways and make wiser choices to never end up in a place like this again, but more than anything, you must run *right now*."

Near tears, Perle could hear the thickness in her own voice as her emotions poured forth. Most of the bandits snickered or laughed outright, certain that she was spinning lies in an effort to save their hides. A select few, however, seemed to take note of the desperation in her voice without any substantial fear. Of those, a handful realized that, right or wrong, this woman truly believed they were seconds away from death. Some chose to ignore that realization; others edged their way toward the campsite's boundary.

The leader was not among those, as he was already striding toward Perle, hand outstretched with dirty, ash-stained fingers toward her robes. They never made contact, though. Before he could get near enough to touch her, a smaller hand grabbed his forearm and held it there without so much as a quiver.

Ivan stood, keeping the leader immobilized, watching with a bored expression as the remainder of the bandits readied themselves for what they thought would be a true battle. Knives glimmered in the firelight as they surrounded the newly arrived trio, their deadly intent all too clear.

A whistling sound suddenly stole Perle's attention, along with that of many of the bandits. At the rear of the camp, the knight had finished dealing with the guards, all six men lying in a pained state upon the ground. Task done, the former prisoner was casually whistling as they walked toward the crowd, no concern at all for what should be overwhelming odds.

"Fear not, fair priestess. For I swore to find you, and to protect you if you still lived. These ruffians shall be silenced shortly."

"Big talk for someone who went down with a pitiful fight the first time," snarled the leader, still trying to yank his arm free from Ivan's grip

and failing.

“You mean, when I wanted to be captured because I thought you had the priestess?” Laughter rang out from the armor, unexpectedly harmonic. Since this sound was somewhat less muffled, Perle realized for the first time that their knight’s voice was female, and deeply amused. “This match will go markedly different than our first.”

With a wet *pop*, Ivan tore the arm from the leader’s body, hurling it into the crowd of bandits trying to surround them. “They got their warning and had their chance. Anything more is just wasting our time.”

The stricken silence at Ivan’s sudden act of violence was short-lived, largely thanks to the screams coming from Auro’s surroundings. His vast maw parted once more, Auro was playfully chasing after a group of bandits, several with large bites already taken out. When one slipped, his tongue shot out, snaring a leg and tossing the poor soul down his gullet. It was horrifying, but also the same show she’d seen in the tavern, so Perle found it easier to look away this time.

What greeted her gaze instead was Ivan, standing in front of her, easily dispatching any bandit that came even remotely near. Sometimes, he’d vanish and reappear in the crowd, swing an arm and kill several, only to be back at her side before anyone could advance. At the rear, the knight was making much slower progress, owing to the fact that she was actually subduing her opponents rather than slaughtering them.

The bandit leader himself was still standing, though shock at his missing limb had sent him tumbling back. In an unexpected display of loyalty, several of his men hopped on the wound, binding it with a strip of leather to stem the torrent of blood. Seeming to recover from the shock, he drew himself up tall, and Perle felt something she hadn’t expected from the loud brute. Around and within him, magic began to stir.

“He’s casting,” she yelled to Ivan, pointing quickly to the source.

Ivan repositioned himself between the leader and Perle just in time, as a wave of stone spikes shot forth, spraying across the battlefield. A half-dozen bandits were killed instantly, impaled on their own leader’s strike. Auro took one spear to the gut, which seemed to stagger him, while the others were nimbly dodged. Their newly met knight crossed her arms and hunkered down, allowing the spikes to shatter on the hardest parts of her armor.

As for Ivan, he raised a hand and a wave of *something* washed out. It was magic like Perle had never sensed, a chaotic and twisted force that annihilated all it encountered. The spikes were torn apart, along with the magic moving them. It was perhaps the most disconcerting act she'd seen from him yet, and that was saying something. What would spawn a magic like that, and who would bind themselves to it?

Smacking sounds drew Perle's gaze back to Auro, who'd moved on to theatrically licking his lips. "That one seems particularly delectable."

Whether it was being looked upon as a meal or watching his magic assault have zero impact, the leader seemed to finally be realizing how far out of their depths these enemies were. "Retreat! Run and regroup!"

"No."

The single syllable sent shivers down Perle's spine. In a blink, he was gone, appearing before the first group to break and turn for a run. With a swing of his fist, Ivan ripped through all of their torsos, bisecting them in a bloody spray that washed through the battlefield.

Then he was back in front of Perle, the remains of the other bandits dripping down his sleeve. "You've seen too much. No one else leaves."

It seemed the leader hadn't taken this message to heart, as he was already scrambling away. Perle expected Ivan to vanish again, but it was Auro who darted ahead, the mouth in his chest increasing in size until he was able to snare the leader in a single bite. The effort wasn't quite perfect, however, leaving the leader's head and one arm sticking out as Auro began to chew.

The leader's screams were otherworldly in their pain. Never had Perle imagined what it would be like to get eaten alive, but his sobbing, broken yells begging for death etched a genuine fear of the experience into her heart. Other bandits tried to run in and help, but Auro merely slashed their necks with a wave of his claws, focused instead on his meal-in-progress.

She was vaguely aware of Ivan cleaning up the remaining bandits in short bursts, but Perle couldn't tear herself from the horror being visited on the once threatening terror of a man. She watched him shrink into the enormous maw inch by inch, aware of his fate and unable to escape it. Were it in her power to have taken the pain, she would have, but such was not the nature of her magics. The most she could offer would be mending, a cruel act that would only prolong the suffering.

Instead, Perle fulfilled her role as a priestess and prayed for the man's soul. Whether it was meant to walk the Endless Plains, find another chance at life in the Great Cycle, or be tormented in the lowest chambers of Dark Perdition, she had no say or sway. Perle only prayed that it would reach the destination swiftly, and take its lessons well. She continued on beyond just the leader, praying for the souls of every bandit present, then the ones Auro had eaten, and even the soldiers who'd come for her.

So much death in the span of only a few days, with no signs of slowing down. Was her world always this cruel, and Perle had simply been spared the knowledge? Or was she finding trouble because she'd called forth a beacon for it? How many people would be alive if she hadn't summoned Ivan? It was hard to say for sure, but unfortunately, Perle did know one fact for certain: she wouldn't be among them. Her life would have already ended, yet instead, she persisted while the bodies of Ivan's victims piled up. It was a horrific trade, and worse, one she wasn't sure she'd have had the willpower to resist, even if she'd known the truth going in.

By the time Perle raised her head once more, the killing was done. Whatever bandits had fled during her warning were the only survivors; the rest had been beaten or butchered. Some still clung to life; however, Auro was stalking the battlefield, scooping up every morsel, so their time was severely limited.

Dimly, Perle became aware of a figure moving toward her. She spun to find the knight near, with Ivan appearing at her side moments later. Laying a steadying hand on his arm, Perle stepped forward, though not so close that Ivan couldn't intervene if necessary.

"Priestess of the Lost Moon. I have been searching many months for you." The knight bowed her head, helm not budging in the slightest. "I am called Elya, she who serves the Order of the Shatterfly."

Perle's breath caught in her throat as she looked over the figure anew. Neither Ivan nor Auro reacted to the name, which made sense given that one was from another world and the other had been trapped in a swamp with little of his sanity.

"Months, you say? I haven't been drawing attention for all that long."

"Likely I was on your trail the moment your current path began. As I said, an oracle sent me to find you, indicating that it was of the utmost importance. She feared you were going to bring forth a creature into our



world you couldn't control, one with the power to end entire kingdoms if it so desired."

With an audible creak, the helmet turned toward Ivan, though the knight herself remained stationary. "It seems you've already succeeded, however."

"And if I have?" Perle held her voice steady, refusing to flinch at the accusations. None of it was news to her; Perle had already realized the danger in leaning on Ivan. Let free, there was truly no imagining the destruction he could wreak.

More creaking as the helmet turned back. "Then I would ask for what purpose you have brought him. While many codes of knighthood are rigid, my order has an understanding of adaptation."

"Ivan has been brought here as an instrument of vengeance against the demon Dezzolorth, the gutless beast that slew my uncle. He will not stop until justice is delivered. Though I shall try to direct his fury toward the demons, as you've seen tonight, he will not bend from a challenge. Does that satisfy your curiosity?"

"Not in the slightest, yet it leaves me only one course of action."

Ivan started forward, hand closing into a fist, but he wasn't prepared for Elya to suddenly drop to her knees and hunch forward. "Good priestess, I do humbly ask that you accept this knight's offer of service. Allow me to accompany you in the efforts of slaying one of the demons' great assets."

Already, Ivan was shaking his head. "We don't need more people slowing us down."

"Given how well she fought, I would hardly call her an impediment, and she certainly can't walk much slower than I do," Perle countered. Noticing his unyielding stare, she decided to adjust her approach. "Do you have shatterflies on your world, Ivan?"

"Not so far."

"Then allow me to explain. A shatterfly is a particularly weak insect with a limited lifespan, yet it is hardly ever preyed upon by larger creatures. The reason is that, when threatened, the shatterfly emits a high-pitched screech that causes its own body to explode, shards of its outer shell sent flying in all directions, usually killing or crippling whatever tried to hurt it. Though they lead short, humble lives, no one forgets a shatterfly when it dies."

Rising to her feet, the knight nodded, her helm making the process especially audible. "My order is for those with limited time, and a firm goal

in how we wish to spend it.”

Slinking over, Auro gave Elya a long look up and down, then sniffed the air a half-dozen times. “She’s got quite a few fascinating scents twisting around her, and none stink of betrayal.”

For a fleeting moment, Perle wondered if Auro really could smell something like that. She might have called it impossible only a week prior, but such words were fast losing their meaning.

“Perhaps it might help if you removed your helmet so Ivan can see the truth in your gaze,” Perle suggested, not sure if they were making headway.

To her surprise, Elya shuffled awkwardly in place, a motion made obvious by the groans of her armor. “To speak truly, my face would offer little comfort. As a child, my village was captured by a mad wizard bent on chasing wicked sources of power. We were used as subjects for all manner of magical experimentation. Though I was one of few who survived, what was done remains. It’s the source of my exceptional strength, as well as why I wear armor enchanted to stay on no matter what.”

Fully expecting that to be a stumbling block, Perle was stunned when Ivan’s countenance softened ever so slightly. “Fine. The knight can come. But if I think for a moment she’s betraying us, Elya becomes Auro’s problem.”

For his part, Auro offered a friendly wave, paired with a toothy grin.

“Now, let’s search this camp for valuables and get some rest,” Ivan ordered. “We still have a demon to kill.”

The next two days passed in unexpected peace. As the group headed toward Ravidon, the trading city where Dezzolorth had made his home, they passed through forests and glades, often traipsing along cart paths, but had no altercations. The few other travelers they saw waved from a distance, if that, clearly eager to avoid trouble as well.

Some part of Perle kept expecting monsters to strike, or at least a wild beast, given the dangerous nature of the lands they traveled. These were part of the frontier, far from royal guards to keep the local dangers pacified. Yet not so much as an aggressive rat crossed their path.

The lone monster Perle had managed to spot was a catlike creature with two heads and a stinger on its tail. That experience had only left her more confused, however. They'd come upon the creature midway through a meal, both heads distracted as it devoured a doveer carcass, until it realized company had arrived. Perle readied herself for a fight, only to watch as the monster absolutely *raced* off, leaving claw marks in the grass from the force of its fleeing.

Her only conclusion was that the creatures could sense the danger posed by one or more of her companions. Whether it was the seemingly unstoppable man from another world, the shape-shifting serpent with a taste for human flesh, or the cursed knight loudly clanking along was anyone's guess.

At least Elya made for pleasant company. She and Auro had swiftly fallen into a running conversation of comparing battle stories, regaling them with tales of fighting off trolls, defending towns, and even putting down a demon or two.

It was at the end of one of these tales, on the eve of their second peaceful night, that Ivan spoke up, a rare occasion that drew everyone's interest. "We're getting close enough that it seems prudent to ask. What exactly is a 'demon' in this world? Where I come from, it's tied up in all manner of myth and belief, so I'd like to hear what I should be expecting."

Perle looked at Auro, who affected an expression of mock shock, though she suspected it was there to cover a dash of actual surprise. Elya, however, simply replied. "It is believed the word evolved off the term 'dimension travel,' what demons are at their core. Beings from other worlds, other phases of existence across the Tapestry of All."

"In my world, most people call it a multiverse," Ivan tilted his head back, looking up at the stars. They twinkled beautifully, save for the dark spot where nothing flickered; the place where a gorgeous third moon had once soared through the sky. "By your definitions, wouldn't that make me a demon too?"

"A dirty secret not spoken of in polite company," Auro confirmed. "For generations, our people battled against invaders with various methods and means, but when the summoning option was discovered, it was embraced wholeheartedly. After all, why not conscript demons to fight demons?"

"But most people don't know where the help comes from," Perle corrected. "They only see a great champion sweeping through the land, defending those in need. Not even I was supposed to have known. As a youth, I had a bad habit of sneaking into the library to read tomes above my station."

Auro laughed, and Perle could swear she saw a leaf on a nearby tree wilt. "To think, we all now stand in the shadow of a little child's precocious reading choices."

"So, demons are just people from other worlds who've found their way here and made trouble," Ivan surmised, steering them back to the topic at hand with his usual amount of subtlety. "Then you bring forth more to do the dirty work of handling them. What if the summoned champion doesn't want to play ball?"

Two blank stares and a helm stared back at Ivan, who soon realized he'd used a saying that clearly didn't exist here. "What if they refuse?"

Perle shuffled awkwardly; she'd never forgotten his reaction to the idea of control, the moment she'd felt closest to death. "The summoning does more than just bring them over. Magic must be balanced. Snatching another

being from their world accrues a large mystical debt, so to even the scales, there's also a boon involved. I don't fully understand it, but dragging someone across the Tapestry accumulates a sort of energy. That energy is infused into the champion, rendering them capable of the task for which they were summoned and paying off the debt of their abduction."

"How nice of you." Ivan's tone had grown a touch firmer, which was impressive given its starting point. "I ask again, what if they *refuse*?"

"The debt works both ways," Auro interjected. "We steal them away to our world, and repay them with power. But no one says that's all that can be given. The ceremony itself condenses a great deal of magic from our own world, infusing it into the summoned being as well. Enough that a new debt is created, this time in the summoner's favor. A debt with chains that demand certain levels of compliance."

Facing the ground, Perle's face grew hot at his words. When reading about the ceremony in the tomes, it had seemed like a natural equation. Of course, there would be limits put on a stranger suddenly gifted exceptional abilities. To let them run free would not only be irresponsible, it would potentially unleash another hostile demon upon their land. It was the same reason they could be returned by killing the summoner; a necessary precaution in case of calamity.

But the act of dragging a stranger into her world's fight wasn't so clean cut as the stories described. She'd ripped him from his home, all he knew and loved, and then beseeched him to take up her fight. Was binding him to that task truly necessary as well?

"I see. That's why you had no control. I never allowed any external power into my body. The deal was refused." Ivan was staring hard at the fire now, the flame reflecting in his steady eyes.

"The power is not one of dominance, more of limitations," Perle explained, her voice soft against the night's gentle wind. "It is to stop a newly arrived outsider from striking down innocents, pillaging towns—"

"Fighting for their freedom?" Ivan probed.

"If that freedom takes the form of slaughtering helpless masses, then yes, that too would be denied."

The fire crackled, pops echoing up from several logs, as Ivan continued to stare. "I do understand the sentiment. Why not use demons to fight demons, have them solve the problem they created? But the yoke of control is heavier than you know. Even when it's lifted, memories remain."

“What are you driving at?” Perle asked, curious and terrified in equal measure.

“There are more ways to cross this Tapestry than just summoning. It used to be somewhat commonplace in my world. In fact, I expect one of my... allies is making preparations to come looking for me by now. These champions you summon, train, empower, and then use as weapons, do you not think any of them possessed or found such means? I would wager at least some of your demon invaders were former champions or their associates, seeking a well-earned revenge.”

“You’re saying we caused this problem ourselves,” Elya noted.

Ivan shook his head. “Obviously, there had to be demons first to warrant the initial summoning. I’m just saying that your strategy has almost certainly made it worse. If not for my debt to Fesver, you would not find me nearly so accommodating of the sudden transportation.”

Stepping forward, Auro hunkered down onto one of the felled trees they were using as seats, an unexpectedly serious look on his face. “This seems a good time to bring up an issue which has been flitting about since our first meeting.” With a snap of his hand, he grabbed something out of the air near the fire.

Widening his fingers just enough to allow sight through, Auro revealed a flickering form, like a butterfly made of light. Perle recognized it instantly; she’d been catching glimpses of the strange creature since summoning Ivan, but had taken it as a symptom of exhaustion. Yet now, it was before her, proven to be real, and Perle found herself without explanation.

“For all his might, Ivan wasn’t completely unaffected by the spell. He *is* here, after all, and speaking our language like it’s his mother tongue. But the infusion of power failed, his own magic rebuking a lesser source. Yet the magic *must* be infused for the debt to balance and the spell’s form to solidify. Therefore, it has been lingering about the duo it’s bound to, waiting for a chance to fulfill its purpose.”

“It can wait until the sun dies out. I have no need for what it offers, especially with such chains attached.” Ivan’s tone made it clear the issue was not up for discussion.

Auro was already nodding, though, as if he’d never considered the possibility. “Of course not. Why would you eat a meal you know to be

poisoned, especially when it isn't even sumptuous? There is another, far more interesting candidate to absorb such power."

Cocking an eyebrow, Ivan shifted his gaze toward Elya, who quickly threw up her hands. "I'm afraid my connection to magic is somewhat complicated. The experiments performed left me only attuned to an unnatural form of it, one found in precious little supply across our world. Attempts at incorporating anything else fail, usually in spectacular fashion."

"While I'm noting that away for later discussion, you were not my selection." Auro's grin threatened to split his face, a possibility Perle knew was all too real. "The spell is part of a connection shared by the summoner and the summoned. Since the summoned has rejected the infusion, that makes the summoner the next best candidate."

"Me?" Perle felt like the log had suddenly vanished from beneath her. She'd felt the sorts of magical forces being wielded during the ceremony, the power being pulled in. Imagining that level of energy tearing through her, ripping her apart, terrified Perle to her very core.

But even worse was the realization that followed on its heels. Seeing that power, she'd never once felt a flicker of fear for the person being summoned, who would have had that magic poured into them automatically. She never asked herself if it would hurt, especially after being suddenly torn from everything they knew and loved. Auro appeared to be presenting an option, which was more than she'd done for Ivan.

She had no right to refuse it. More than that, she had a duty to accept.

"You're sure she can withstand it?" Ivan asked.

To that, Auro threw his head back and cackled into the night. "Sure? I am sure of so little it could fit on the tip of one fang, and certainly not the outcome of untested magics. Never have I heard of a summon who could resist the infusion, their unfinished spell flitting about like a common pest. Whether she absorbs it or not, we are charting new territory. I merely advocate steering toward the most fascinating lands."

Staring at the fluttering light in Auro's grip, Perle tried to make sense of the curious shape. All the power that had bent the very ways of the heavens to bring Ivan forth, and it was contained in such an unassuming package? Part of her whispered that there must be more to it, while a deeper voice recanted a piece of her uncle's wisdom, even assuming Fesver's voice.

*Raindrops can shatter mountains when moving fast enough.*

“How would I accept such a power in the first place?” Perle kept her tone even, tipping neither her fear nor interest in the lifelike spell.

“I imagine, as most acts of magic, it begins with an effort of will.” Auro’s fingers parted, and the spell flickered away in a flash of light, darting swiftly away.

Yet it didn’t flee far, hovering around their area, flitting between her and Ivan intermittently. Even watching it directly, Perle had to strain, her gaze naturally trying to shift away. No wonder it had lived at the fringes of her awareness so easily.

Mentally reaching out, Perle found the spell with little effort. It had been waiting for her attention, and now positively pulsed with power. The energy felt as if it would sear her senses just for being near, but she pushed on, trying to draw the power into herself. At the touch of her mind and will, it moved, sending trails of energy toward her.

Rather than winding into her body, however, it merely splashed against her, before flowing back to the fluttering form still flitting about. Once more, Perle attempted to draw in the power, and again it reacted to her desires. But the power found no purchase, splashing off her once more, returning to its source.

“Fascinating, indeed.” Auro had moved closer while she was distracted; he was now so near she could feel his breath with every word. “The connection is there, and the magic is willing, yet it cannot seem to solidify. Something is missing, an anchor for the magic to take hold of.”

“What does that mean?” Ivan asked bluntly.

“Remember, this is all mere conjecture on my part. But I would say there is a component necessary in the spell’s equation that has not yet been accounted for. It might be a physical material, such as the potent gantala root, where ingesting the missing piece will fix the issue. Then again, it could just as easily be something more conceptual. There are few things magic enjoys more than a riddle.”

It still struck Perle as curious, the way Auro talked of magic. That said, he’d been the one to notice the spell dancing around her, and he was the only person among them with any idea of what to *do* about it. Perhaps his concept of magic had more validity than her order would care to believe.

“Meaning it might be eventually useful, or it could prove pointless.” Letting out a long sigh, Ivan shook his head. “This is why I rarely bother with casting magic. Too unreliable and unpredictable.”



“I would argue those are two of magic’s greatest strengths, especially in combat,” Auro replied.

Elya’s nodding was loud enough to draw attention, thanks to the creaks in her helm. Even when they rested, she remained fully armored; Perle only hoped the suit had some comfort enchantments woven in. “I’m on Ivan’s side for this one. A sure strike is a lot more dependable than some quick-muttered spell. Magic is best when used in preparation *for* battle, not during it.”

Looking back and forth between them, Auro gathered himself up, standing taller as his back straightened. “What I am hearing is that neither of you two has been privy to a display of *proper* spellcasting. I assure you that afterwards, you will have very different opinions on the validity of magic mid-battle.”

“Unless I’ve lost my bearings, you’ll get a chance to show us tomorrow,” Elya replied. “Ravidon is about half a day’s journey from here.”

Half a day. Half a day until she met her uncle’s killer, no longer the terrified little girl running for her life. She was still scared, even more so than in the initial surge of panic, but that fear was tempered by fury and hope. Half a day until Dezzolorth met her champion.

Half a day until it was *his* turn to know fear.

Perle realized that Ivan was watching her, though for what, she hadn’t any idea. His gaze was heavy, though, enough that she turned to face it. The two of them locked eyes and remained that way for a long stretch, wrapped in silence save for crackles from the fire.

“What comes next will be hard,” he said at last.

“I’m aware. Dezzolorth has conscripted a great many former enemies under his rule, and has fortified Ravidon heavily. Breaching the exterior without being spotted alone will take tremendous fortune, to say nothing of swiftly hunting him down.” Perle had seen the battalions under Dezzolorth’s control from a distance, and large enough to shiver at the mere memory.

Ivan shook his head. “The killing will be easy. If this Dezzolorth was strong enough to be a challenge for me... let’s just say he wouldn’t need a fortress city to feel safe. It’s the other part that you should be ready for.”

He stood from his seat, breaking their gaze and looking up into the sky, lingering on the hole where a glorious moon had once shone. “When vengeance is all that’s pushing you forward, not many people are prepared

for what comes after they get it. No more targets to look toward, or righteous fire to keep you going. What becomes of Perle the priestess once she finally gets her revenge?”

“I don’t know,” she admitted. “I’ve never felt close enough to that goal where it mattered.”

The firelight bathed Ivan in a wicked red glow as his face shifted downward, serious as the grave. “Then the time has come for consideration. Dezzolorth killed one of the very few people in this life I’ve counted as a friend. Tomorrow, he will scream until I’m satisfied. And you will have some decisions to make.”

Perle nodded, unsure of what words to reach for. Rather than try, she looked to the stars once more. When the deed was done and Fesver avenged, would she be satisfied? More than that, did she have the right to ask Ivan for help, given what she’d already done to him. He’d hinted at being open to the idea, but if she did... if she kept Ivan here, people would die. That was a fundamental truth that had been proven more than enough times. Whether they deserved it or not, those lives still ended because of Perle’s actions.

What would the cost to her soul be, for allowing such destruction? And what would it cost the world if she refused to pay?

## 8

Once, the town of Ravidon had been a bustling place, a handy stopover along the kingdom roads that grew steadily thanks to the influx of trade. Inns were always full, as were the taverns attached, and shops overflowed with goods from entire regions away. Though certainly no true metropolis, it had thrived, the population content and well cared for thanks to competent leaders making use of the constant gold. Not to mention protectors like her uncle to help keep the peace.

The roads thick with travelers were a thing of the past. As Perle walked alongside her companions, she stared up and down at the empty expanse before them. In the distance, she could see the tips of Ravidon's walls poking over the trees. By this point, they should be jostling to make way; instead, they had only space.

"There are watchtowers along the walls," Elya informed them, pointing off into the distance, farther than Perle's eyes could track. "We're likely to be spotted, if we haven't been already."

"And the priestess is still in her ever-so-distinct robes," Auro added.

At that, Perle stiffened. She'd forgotten about the watchtowers, and had failed to realize the robes would give her away. Dezzolorth had sent a lot of people after her. If word got out that she was coming... who knew what horrors he'd prepare?

Ivan, however, was unconcerned. "Good. If they see Perle, then they'll probably mount an attack. Without her, there was the risk they'd run."

An objection started to bubble up on her lips, yet Perle pushed it down. Was she really going to voice concern for Ivan's safety again? How many miraculous feats would it take before she accepted the reality of her

situation? She had no idea what Ivan's limits were, only a strong suspicion that he'd yet to put forth any real effort whatsoever.

"We are at our weakest when victory hangs near, and at our most dangerous when defeat looms overhead." Elya's calm voice was a sharp contrast to the constant racket made by her armor. After the first few hours of travel, Perle was tempted to ask if Auro knew any sound-canceling spells.

"Is that advice for us, or the town?" Auro asked.

"Depends on who's closer to victory in the moment."

Elya's response hung over them for some time, until they rounded a bend in the road.

It was then that Ravidon fully came into view, and a gasp from Perle broke the settled silence. Bodies lined the walls, knights and peasants, men and women, all skewered up for display. There had been a few the last time she was here, but now it looked like a ghastly battalion had been set to keep watch. And perched slightly above the others, placed so he couldn't be missed, was the familiar body of her uncle, the man named Fesver.

Her first thought at the sight was a curious one; she found herself puzzled by the fact that his head was once more joined to his body. Someone had gone to all the trouble of reattaching it, just to have a whole corpse to put on display. Then the moment of shock wore off, and Perle was overcome by nausea. If not for the horrors she'd witnessed over the last few days, her stomach would have voided itself right then and there.

Auro was uncharacteristically silent, while Elya appeared to have lowered her head in some manner of prayer. Perle felt a pang of guilt. That should have been *her* first response, yet revulsion had overwhelmed her. Upon looking at Ivan, though, Perle felt an emotion that utterly eclipsed her sight of the corpse wall.

Absolute, overwhelming terror flooded through her at the sight of Ivan's face. Until that moment, she'd only ever caught glimpses beneath the detached, bored demeanor. Flickers of what simmered below, like when he'd thought she might try to control him through magic. Now, the mask had been fully ripped away, and Perle could see the inferno of endless fury that dwelled beneath that cold outer shell.

Somehow, in all the madness of the summoning, finding Auro, fighting bandits, saving Elya, and trying to stay alive, Perle had forgotten that Ivan wasn't doing any of this for her. He and Fesver had been friends. Now, he

was staring at the corpse of that friend mounted as a warning, a taunt to all who entered the man's own hometown.

Over the span of seconds, Ivan regained control of his expression, the anger once more hidden, yet Perle could never forget what she saw. What kind of life did one have to live to be capable of that much fury, that much *hate*? She couldn't imagine, but Perle knew one thing with absolute certainty: that blade of rage was pointed directly at Dezzolorth.

"I'm not much for plans," Ivan said at last. "Ordinarily, I would simply go in and wipe out the enemy, but they'll certainly have taken hostages. Letting these fucks cut through the people of Fesver's town is a poor repayment for what I owe, so I'd like to avoid it. Auro, Elya, if I keep Dezzolorth busy, can you help the residents?"

"For the man who freed me from my noxious swamp and set me upon a path of endless morsels? I shall endeavor with all my heart to see you delighted." Auro gave a deep bow with his response, though his eyes never strayed from Ivan.

Elya kept things simpler. "Count on me. Fighting off a town full of demon invaders is certainly a death worthy of a Shatterfly Knight."

Nodding at them both, Ivan then turned to Perle. "Did Fesver ever tell you about the magic of his sword?"

"He kept its workings a secret, even from the most trusted of allies. I've seen him cut through multiple trees like twigs, yet for me, it's barely more than a hunk of metal." The sword in question hung heavy on Perle's side, where it had lived since Ivan's summoning. It was more keepsake than tool in hands like hers, a symbol of what had been lost.

Reaching to his side, Ivan patted the left section of his stomach. "He used it to cut *through* me, attacking the monster that was feeding on us both. I didn't think anything could break my skin in those days, and he went and plunged cold metal right through my torso. It was a shock to him, too. That was the day Fesver learned the secret of his sword's magic, and I was there to listen as he puzzled it together."

Ivan lowered his gaze to the blade, eyes drifting through the past, to a time when another hand had wielded it. "The blade's ability to cut is tied to the user's determination. How badly do they need to slice through what stands before, and how driven are they to strike? It doesn't demand a specific lineage or vast magical powers. Its magic is as potent in the hands of a child as a seasoned killer."

Perle wanted to object at the simplicity; surely, it couldn't be something that straightforward. Yet when she considered her own experiences holding the sword, his words rang true. When had she ever swung with true intent to do harm? At best, it was wielded as a defensive measure, hoping to block incoming threats.

Her hand tightened on the hilt as Ivan turned back to the road, advancing once more. Auro and Elya followed, as did Perle after a few moments. Yet the weight of her own questions slowed her feet; would the people of the town truly be all right, what was lying in wait, why had Ivan told her about the sword, and why wait until now to do it? Finally, Perle was forced to shove her concerns aside, as the group had started to pull ahead.

The attack was happening. It might have been her hand that set it all in motion, but she could no longer halt what had begun. Not unless she found the determination to run Fesver's sword through her own heart and send Ivan home. But he'd kept his word about the bandits, allowing those who ran early to scamper free. Maybe there was hope for the citizens of Ravidon yet. After all, Ivan seemed to have little interest in any of the other humans they'd dealt with.

His gaze had remained steady since arrival: always locked on vengeance. And now the object of that grudge was on the other side of a corpse-laden wall, with no idea what was walking toward his front door. Despite her fears and worries, Perle felt a smile fighting to touch her face.

Even if it did end up costing her soul, at least she'd get to see Fesver's murder avenged. There were worse bargains to be made.

As they drew near, a loud grinding sound suddenly ripped through the air. Elya stiffened, Auro took a step back, and Ivan showed no concern whatsoever, not even slowing his stride. Perle was the only one among them who recognized the sound, confusion tinging her voice as she explained. "They're... opening the gates?"

"Smart call," Ivan muttered. "Those look annoying to replace."

Sure enough, the large wooden gates barring entrance to Ravidon were slowly parting, revealing a crowded central courtyard. They were waiting for her. For her group, for what was meant to be the last hope of her world. How? Who had survived to run ahead and warn Dezzolorth?

Like the thought had conjured him, a deep, wretched voice called out from the town, traveling the short distance that still remained.

“She returns at last! Fesver’s kin, the sword thief, bringing her summoned champion in tow.”

Laughter rang out from other coarse voices scattered among the crowd—Dezzolorth’s fellow demons. Although the barb had been meant to taunt, it instead set Perle’s nerves at ease. Dezzolorth knew about her stolen pages; he’d sent troops specifically to stop her from succeeding. It made sense he’d deduce her success, as well as the motivation for her return.

In short, Dezzolorth knew she had a champion. He had no idea what that really meant, though. Otherwise, he’d have started running and never quit. Not until his legs were taken.

Since Ivan never slowed, Perle hurried to catch up. She glanced around and saw Elya and Auro coming around a tree that had been slightly away from the road, but they too quickly joined with the group. Together, the four of them walked through the vast gates, into the town’s central courtyard, where Perle had attended weddings, festivals, and even a few duels.

Now, she saw the defeated faces of those who remained. Some wore hopeful expressions and armor, traitors who’d abandoned their own people for a modicum of promised safety, but most were downcast. Though she hoped that wouldn’t be the case for much longer.

Standing amongst them, towering over the humans, were five of Dezzolorth’s demons. Some invaders from other worlds appeared the same as its native residents, like Ivan, but this brood was not such a case. Whatever world they’d hailed from had left them tall and muscular, with skin colored a mottled purple, spines extending from their torsos, and teeth capable of chewing through rocks.

Or bone, as the town’s people had learned all too well.

In the center of the courtyard, tallest of his demons, was Dezzolorth. Aside from his greater size, he was instantly recognizable for the set of four horns ringing his skull, and the scar covering his left eye. While the bastard might have killed Fesver, he hadn’t gotten away unscathed. There was a toothy grin stretched across his face as she stepped fully into view.

“So very bold, to walk right through the front gates. You certainly inherited your uncle’s hubris.”

Ignoring Dezzolorth’s words, Ivan tapped her on the shoulder. “Is that the one?”

“You must be the champion, then. I was getting to you, but fine.” Dezzolorth raised his hand, and suddenly, each demon reached out,

grabbing hold of a nearby civilian. They began screaming immediately, lifted into the air, hovering dangerously close to those sharp mouths.

Attacking the people they were meant to protect, just like he had with Fesver. Perle tried to object, but her voice was stuck, suddenly caught in the same painful memories that had driven her here. Thankfully, her champion had no such issue.

“Do you know why I think summoning an outsider to fight probably proves especially effective, compared to nurturing the same power amongst one of your own? Simple perspective.” Ivan took a step forward, causing several demons to twitch. “I don’t give a fuck about this world or the people in it. You think I’m going to lie down and die for what might as well be figments of my imagination? Tough shit. If you killed everyone here, I would feel *nothing*. But you all...”

Ivan vanished and reappeared next to one of the demons, ripping off the arm it was using to hold a civilian hostage. That was merely the first strike, however, as in a series of rapid movements, he’d taken away the other arms, both legs, its eyes, and finally, its lower jaw.

Then he was back in his starting position, yellow blood dripping down his hands. “That one twitched.” His eyes traced the courtyard, briefly staring at every demon present. “Be careful I don’t suspect anyone else is about to take a bite. And as I was saying, you all seem to know one another. If I kill all your forces, you’ll care quite a lot.”

Where the demon wailed in pain, the nearby citizens stared on in wonder. They’d been losing for so long, the demons seemed unbeatable no matter their efforts, and now, one of their captors lay helpless, ripped apart like a discarded toy.

Dezzolorth took it all in calmly, weighing the scene before him. “You can’t save them all.”

“But I can show less mercy than with the first one,” Ivan replied, tone equally cool. “Demon or human, if they harm an innocent, I hope they’re eager to see just how much pain I can truly inflict. I’ve never been much of an instrument for protection. Vengeance, on the other hand...”

“Think I’ll just let you take your time cutting through my people?” From the ground, Dezzolorth hefted a massive club, the dark metal stained with a myriad of different blood.

Pointing back to the first wailing demon, Ivan nodded. “You already did.”



Whether it was the tension or the insanity of the situation, Perle felt a small giggle slip through her lips at the exchange. Like a spark among tinder, it spread through the townsfolk, most already certain of their deaths. Why not laugh then, for the brief moment they had something to enjoy? Why not chuckle before the demons retook control and the blood flowed in earnest?

Unfortunately, hearing the people he'd been dominating laugh at his perceived failure lit a dark rage in Dezzolorth. "Troops, I want you to start butchering and not stop until their champion is dead. The harder he fights, the longer they suffer. Kill his allies, too. Except the priestess—she's already spoken for."

Perle barely had time to wonder what exactly *that* meant before the air was filled with screams and gasps. It was a mixture of fear at the declaration, panic at the implications, and shock at seeing two of the people traveling with Perle suddenly vanish into wisps of fog.

She stared at the spot where Auro and Elya had been moments prior, before a horrified scream jerked her attention to the crowd. Ready to see a helpless townsfolk laid low, she was instead treated to the sight of an armored soldier desperately gripping the street's flagstones as a tongue around his ankle yanked him back. The mouth it was connected to already had a half-dozen arms sticking out, and Auro was only growing larger as he ran, flashing claws tearing out throats.

A demon's roar split the day—a bellow of pain, rather than triumph. Elya had punched directly through its knee, sending the towering enemy collapsing to the ground. As it landed, the knight was waiting, grabbing hold of its head and driving her own knee deep into the demon's skull. It screamed in pain, yet endured; strong as Elya was, she couldn't match Ivan for raw force and kill with a single blow. That was fine, though, because she rammed her knee in three more times, until the demon's face resembled a bloody crater and its final twitches had stopped.

Quickly, Perle scanned the area, hunting for the other three, only to find Ivan tossing the head of the last one at Dezzolorth's feet. The largest demon was fuming, swinging his club for all he was worth, but Ivan merely teleported out of range, back to where he'd been standing. Slowly, she realized that just because Dezzolorth decided to engage didn't mean that Ivan was obligated to play along. He utilized his mobility to keep wiping out the ancillary threats, trusting Auro and Elya to cover the rest.

Though there were still some of the traitorous human forces, they were gravely outnumbered, and without the demons as their backers, the townspeople weren't nearly so afraid. In the span of less than a minute, the entire tide of battle had changed. That was what it meant to fight against an overwhelming, unstoppable force.

That was the fate of those who faced her champion.

With a mighty bellow, Dezzolorth charged Ivan once more, moving faster this time. A red aura oozed out from his skin, muscles bulging and eyes pulsing. He was burning through magic, determined to land a hit and show his might. Rather than vanish, Ivan stood resolute, waiting patiently as the threat drew near.

Perle expected him to duck aside, or nimbly avoid the blow, perhaps even turn its momentum back at Dezzolorth. What she hadn't at all anticipated was that Ivan, the man holding all of her world's hopes on his shoulders, would simply stand there as the club came down, smashing directly onto his skull.

# 9

“D amn it.”

Dezzolorth’s grin of triumph slowly morphed into a grimace of horror. Lifting the massive club, he revealed an unharmed Ivan standing in the road, cracks below his feet and a huge dent in the metal weapon overhead.

“I *knew* not to get my hopes up, I did. But after hearing so much about demons, and learning what we really are, some part of me still wondered if just maybe, you’d have some actual strength. Enough for a *little* fun.”

With a tremendous roar, Dezzolorth whipped his club through the air, smashing it down on Ivan again and again. Every strike caused the road to shatter, and the weapon quickly became deformed from the rapid accumulation of dents. Yet through it all, Ivan stood. It wasn’t even that he resolutely endured the rain of blows; he barely appeared to notice them.

Dezzolorth was unleashing a fury that would turn entire battalions into splattered remains, and Ivan was bored. Finally, the attack halted as Ivan caught hold of the club, effortlessly keeping it restrained.

“I think we’ve established that quantity isn’t going to cut it. If you have any aces in the... damn it, that might not translate. If you have any final tricks to win a fight, now is the time to bring them out. Otherwise, I’ll start showing you some of mine.” Ivan released the club, causing Dezzolorth to stumble backward.

The demon recovered quickly, however. Casting a brief glance to his dead brethren and the quickly shrinking troops under his command, Dezzolorth narrowed his eyes and drew in a deep breath. Red light once more surged along his body, this time weaving directly into the physical

flesh. Muscles swelled, bones stretched—even the horns on his head grew to a full foot long. In the span of ten seconds, Dezzolorth had become something truly inhuman.

Releasing an incoherent bellow, he struck at Ivan once more, hitting so hard the weakened club shattered entirely. Dezzolorth never paused for a moment, fists raining down in place of the ruined weapon. Dirt from the already broken road rose up like a cloud, only the top of the demon visible over his obfuscation as he pounded down unceasingly.

But Perle was done being shocked by Ivan's might. When the monster suddenly went flying, she was unsurprised to see Ivan step out from the cloud, unharmed save for some dirt on his clothes. His expression was still vacant, unimpressed. For anyone else, to allow a demon time to reach their greatest potential was the utmost folly, yet for Ivan, it hadn't even added any sport.

"Anything besides the old 'bigger muscles, hit harder' routine?" Ivan prodded. "Maybe some fancy spell to trip me up, or a third form with a little more versatility?"

Dezzolorth screeched, racing toward Ivan, gouging out chunks of the stone road as he ran. The huge fist never met its target, however. With an economical motion, Ivan took a slight step to the side and leaned inward, meeting the demon's bulk as it continued advancing. He struck with a simple jab of his own, and Dezzolorth was once more sent hurtling back.

"As I said, if you're out of tricks, then it's my turn."

Dezzolorth's next bellow was cut short as Ivan appeared before him without warning, slamming a fist into the demon's jaw, sending his head rocketing to the side. Yet it was nothing compared to the strike that followed, what looked like a simple punch to an enormous purple elbow.

The explosion of yellow blood and purple muscle splashed across Ivan's face, along with his clothes and the ground. Dezzolorth's left arm lay on the broken stone road, hand still clutched tightly into a fist. A whimpering howl broke from the demon's fractured jaw, Dezzolorth's size fading as his magic ran dry. Ivan paid the weakening no attention, grabbing hold of his opponent's remaining arm and tearing it free. More gore washed over him, as unnoticed as a gentle afternoon breeze.

The priestess in Perle wanted to call out for Ivan to end it, that this was enough. Yet no such words rose to her lips. Her uncle's corpse was mounted over the entrance behind her, head stitched back on after the now pitiful

demon before them had sliced it off with Fesver's own sword. When it was over, Perle would seek atonement from a fellow follower of the cloth, even setting her robes aside if it was deemed necessary.

For today, she merely reveled, savoring each cry as Ivan loomed over the beaten demon. A swift kick destroyed Dezzolorth's left knee, then his right, leaving the once mighty monster entirely helpless. Far from the pair, Auro and Elya had gathered the armored humans that served the demons together, their weapons now in the hands of the subjugated townsfolk. One by one, the humans were taking their vengeance, crimes committed under perceived impunity meeting with bloody justice.

She should be stopping them, appealing to their better natures. But these were soldiers who'd once sworn themselves to her uncle's service, an oath of duty to protect those under their care to the very end. A vow he had followed, and they had broken to spare their own skins. Perle took no pleasure in the fate they'd earned, but she wouldn't raise a hand to stay it either.

Perhaps that was why she'd summoned something as wicked as Ivan. The summoners were meant to be true-hearted. If the day had shown her anything, it was how unworthy she'd always been to call herself a priestess. A favorite of Perle's teachers would say that none were worthy to channel the grace of divine beings, yet the gods were wise enough to wield even such imperfect weapons.

That kind old man had been torn apart when her temple was burned; she'd found pieces of him scattered on her way to the library.

Ivan grabbed Dezzolorth by the back of his skull, lifting him up to a kneeling position. It had to be torturous, given his ruined knees, and still the demon tried to hide his pain, staring angrily at Ivan with all the hate those vile yellow eyes could muster.

Yet Ivan wasn't looking back; even now, he seemed to regard the monster as little more than an afterthought. Instead, his gaze was fixed pointedly on Perle.

"The time has come to make your choice."

"I want him dead," she replied instantly.

The barest hint of a grin touched Ivan's mouth, though only for a moment. "That happens regardless. The question is, which of us is going to do it?"

Momentarily taken aback, Perle laid her hand on Fesver's sword, feeling the weight. She wanted it. She did. But Perle wasn't sure she had it in her to end a life, even one like Dezzolorth's. So long as it got done, that would be satisfaction enough.

"I don't—"

"Make *certain* you understand the consequences of your answer, Perle the Priestess." Ivan's tone had grown heavy, and for the first time since entering the town, he didn't appear bored in the slightest. "If I kill this bastard, then my debt to Fesver is paid. We're even, and I'm done here. Even if I can't leave immediately, I'll vanish until someone comes to get me."

And the rest of the world would keep losing its fight. Dezzolorth was one demon of many, and far from the highest ranking among them. With Ivan's power, there was no telling how many battles could be won, the number of lives that could be saved.

"However," Ivan continued, "I can't claim this kill without offering it to you first. Between us, you have the truer claim. More importantly, it's a chance I think Fesver would want me to offer. And if you kill the demon, my debt is still unpaid. So I'll satisfy it by following along on your campaign for a while longer, guiding Fesver's kin as he once helped to guide me."

Her hand was still gripping the sword, so hard her fingers were growing numb. Perle wanted to be angry at him for planning such a cold choice to force upon her, but she recognized the hypocrisy at work. This was *her* fight from the start, her world's struggle. She'd dragged Ivan into it, and he'd delivered exactly what was promised: Dezzolorth's life, resting in her hands.

Still, she was surprised to see his violence restrained. Perle had expected the demon to die as soon as Ivan was in striking distance; instead, she'd underestimated her champion's cruelty. Perle managed to summon up a single question, her voice thicker than she'd expected. "Why?"

"Because salvation comes with blood on your hands."

Ivan motioned, sending a spray of viscera from his sleeves. "The sooner you understand that, the better." He was all but coated in the demon's yellow blood, and appeared entirely unbothered. Because he *was* unbothered, Perle understood. Ivan had walked through so much death that

even being splattered in his enemy's remains was utterly mundane. That was where this path led.

Yet as Perle gathered her strength to refuse, her eyes trailed around to the remainder of the town. The demons, torn to pieces. The traitors, being punished. The townsfolk, free once more. Blood had flown freely today, but when they left, it would be a safer Ravidon in their wake. This too was part of Ivan's offer.

What was Perle willing to trade for the future of her entire world? Were ethics really more sacred than life itself? What was one soul's virtue weighed against the suffering of so many? And would refusing even be the righteous path, or was she selfishly choosing her own perceived integrity over a chance to save countless innocents?

As the questions stormed through her mind, Perle's grip on the sword tightened further. She wished Fesver were here to offer guidance, to help her see the best way forward. Only, he was gone, cut down by the monster kneeling helpless before her. Perle would never get to ask him for advice, or comfort, or tales of her parents ever again.

How many others were like her, weeping for what they'd already lost? How many were cowering in their homes, praying for some miracle to stop the encroaching darkness? No... not some miracle. They were praying for *her*. Her champion, her opportunity, her chance that she'd given the world.

Slowly, Perle drew Fesver's sword. It was heavy in her slender arms, yet the grip felt perfect, like it was fashioned with her in mind. Her approach to the demon was slow, though not from fear. It was hard to believe this pitiful pile of broken limbs had ever tormented her nightmares so. Now that Perle had glimpsed a real monster, she saw the demon for the miserable pretender it was.

No, Perle walked slowly so that Dezzolorth would have a chance to understand his fate. The demon tried in vain to struggle, only to find Ivan yanking one of its horns forward, stretching out Dezzolorth's neck. This would be her first kill, or really, her first murder. There was no honor of battle here; Perle was acting as an executioner.

Steeling her nerves, she lifted the sword overhead and brought it plunging down, slamming into Dezzolorth's neck. When the sword bounded back, Perle very nearly caught it against her face, twisting aside at the last second and falling to the ground.

Laughter rang through the square, stilted and painful, but laughter all the same. Dezzolorth was cackling at her futile efforts; the blade had left only the barest scratch on his thick purple skin. Perle felt her face grow flush as she rose to her feet, knocking the dust from her robes out of habit. Shame clawed at her gut. She'd felt so certain, yet the sword clearly disagreed.

Perle braced for Ivan's disappointment, informing her that she'd blown her chance. Instead, he said nothing, only continued to hold Dezzolorth in place. Moving unsteadily, Perle retrieved her uncle's sword and approached once more, eyeing Ivan uncertainly. "Did I fail?"

"That depends on you."

Against her better judgment, Perle nodded to the scratch on the still laughing demon's neck. "My sword isn't sharp enough."

"Maybe so," Ivan agreed. "But there's more than one kind of determination."

Suspicion gave way to understanding as Perle pieced his words together. It seemed this wasn't a decision she got to make in the snap of a moment. Walking this path would take a constant toll. In a way, she couldn't have asked for a better first step.

Lifting the sword once more, Perle brought it down again, and as before, it bounced back from the thick skin. She'd slightly missed the spot of her first blow, leaving a second scratch behind on the demon's neck. Then a third. Then a fourth.

By her tenth strike, sweat was already running down Perle's face. She had little physical conditioning, and every swing of the sword contained all of her strength. By her twentieth, Perle's exhausted panting could be heard through the courtyard, though it was largely muffled by Dezzolorth's snickering.

That ended on the thirty-fourth strike, when Perle drew blood. Only a trickle, where her dozens of scratches had finally given way to something more. Her thirty-fifth, driving into the exposed muscle of his neck, earned a muted whine. It had been funny when the sword could do no damage; however, if it could hurt the demon a *little*, that was actually far worse than if it wounded him normally.

Because Perle wasn't stopping. She paid no attention to the yellow blood oozing down from the blade to the hilt, running between her fingers. Nor she did give any mind to the growing terror in Dezzolorth's eyes. Perle



didn't even notice the butterfly of light flapping more adamantly in the side of her vision before vanishing. All she saw, all she focused on, was the neck before her.

Blow after blow fell on the wound, widening it slightly with each strike. Perle couldn't feel her arms or back, her robes were covered in sweat and yellow blood, and at some point, she realized she'd started crying. Tears ran freely down her cheeks as Perle struck again.

When she finally reached his throat, Dezzolorth began to truly panic. The long stretch of his execution had given him time to recover, and he tried in vain to wiggle free of Ivan's unyielding grip. There was no give whatsoever, his skull still held firmly in place as Perle's sword landed once more, drawing a pained rasp of air.

Around her, she could hear the town gathering; the task had taken so long they were done dealing with the traitors. Now, they'd come to witness the execution of their chief tormentor. If Perle asked, she knew there would be a sea of arms willing to take up the sword and see the job through, just like she realized they'd never get a chance. If she turned away, Ivan would finish the job, taking their world's hope in the process.

Even with his throat struck, Dezzolorth's hardiness was proving itself. Rasping for air, the demon still lived, so Perle could only continue her horrid work. Up and down went the sword, the burning etching into her arms. Actually, Perle felt like her entire body was warm. It was an oddity, but paled in comparison to the deed before her. Were the feeling to herald her own death, Perle's course wouldn't be changed.

Wet squelches and gooey thwacks had begun to accompany the blows as they landed, along with muffled screams. Finally, mercifully, Perle cut through Dezzolorth's vocal cords, putting an end to his yells and whimpers. She didn't stop when he went silent, however. Nor did she quit when the body went slack and the struggling ceased.

Not until her blade passed cleanly through to the other side was she content. Not until it was Dezzolorth's head lying on the ground, a town full of witnesses watching on in shock. That was the fate he'd damned Fesver to, so she'd permit the demon to share it.

When the last blow landed and the head came free, Perle staggered away, letting the sword clatter to the ground behind her. She made it barely five steps before collapsing to her hands and knees. It all came flooding out;

her tears turned to outright weeping, her disgust to a voiding of the stomach.

There was no telling how long Perle was like that before she felt a gentle hand on her back, accompanied by perhaps the last voice she'd expected. "The first kill is always the hardest, emotionally speaking. Some will be tougher to put down, but nothing sticks with you like your first." Ivan's tone was soft, almost kind, the strangeness of it helping to pull Perle back to her senses.

"What... what happens now?"

"In the broader scheme, I have no real idea. This is your world, not mine. How we save it is a question only you can answer."

An old proverb of Fesver's rose to Perle's lips. "The payment for excellence is further duty."

"Huh, we have a version of that one, too. No good deed goes unpunished." Ivan rose back to his feet, offering Perle a hand up as well.

She accepted, pulling herself together as best she could despite the dismal state of her appearance. No sooner had she reached her feet than Perle was nearly knocked off them again as a wave of water crashed over her, strong enough to send her back to the ground, if not for Ivan's grip. The sudden sea surrounding her swirled intensely for several seconds before tearing loose and splashing to the ground.

"Best if you're presentable for what comes next," Auro said by way of explanation, his toothy smile on full display.

While she hadn't appreciated the surprise, Perle couldn't argue with the results. Auro's waves turned out to be a stronger version of the cleaning spell he'd used outside the Wallowing Sow. They had not only scrubbed away most of the blood and bile from her robes, but she'd been thoroughly dried when the water was pulled away. For the first time in many days on the road, Perle looked the part of a proper priestess once more.

No matter how little she felt the title was deserved.

"I may not have a plan for the long term, but in a more immediate sense, it's clear what we need to do. My friend is not a fucking wall decoration. Fesver will be buried, as will the rest of the town." Ivan's eyes were already pointed outside of the town's walls, where ample rolling grasslands could be seen. "You handle the rites. I'll take care of the graves. I've had practice."

Much as she wanted to inquire more, Perle had fallen down on enough of her duties for one day. Lacking though she was, the rites had to be performed. Better a poor priestess than none at all. If it was her final act while wearing the cloth, she could think of few better farewells.

With the headless demon lying only a few feet away, Perle prepared to lay her uncle to rest.

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## IO

**I**t was well after dusk when the final body had been laid to rest. Funerals were largely reserved for those upon the wall; however, a few of the slain men in armor were also buried by their families. Traitors or not, there would be people who mourned them, and Perle made no objections to conducting each one's final rites.

As for the demons and unclaimed turncoats, they were largely piled into a massive hole Ivan had torn into the dirt. Once all had been collected, pitch was thrown atop, and the fire took them all. Save only for Dezzolorth's head, which had remained in Ivan's possession, though he wouldn't speak to why. Not that anyone dared to ask.

After the brutal display upon their arrival, the townsfolk were giving Perle's team a wide berth. She was the sole exception they would speak to, and even then, there was always a flicker of suspicion dancing in their gaze. Once, it might have wounded her, but her emotional exhaustion was too thorough in that moment. It was hard to feel anything other than tired.

Familiar clanking came from her side, and Perle turned to find Elya standing near. Though it was impossible to read her expression through the ever-present helm, the armored ally did offer a comforting hand upon her shoulder. "Taking a life, no matter how well deserved, enacts a cost. A price that must be paid, a burden to be carried. If possible, draw comfort in knowing that I have seen few deaths more deserved than Dezzolorth's."

"Thank you," Perle mustered, the words soft upon her lips. "I don't... I don't regret it. I'm just..." Her hands started to shake, and a shockingly gentle gauntlet came down to rest on top.

"It will grow better, with time."

Empty as she thought she was, Perle found a few rogue tears slipping down her cheeks without warning, her voice cracking on the simple rebuttal. “Should it?”

Wordlessly, Elya pulled the priestess into a hug, holding her as she fought to hold back another tirade of sobs.

Across the courtyard, Ivan and Auro watched the display, the latter nodding in approval. “Picking up the knight was a wise call. She’s closer to human, better able to offer comfort in these moments.”

Ivan merely grunted, eyes scanning the dark sky overhead as stars began to twinkle.

“Do you think she’s even noticed that the spell finally bonded? I thought for sure Perle would catch on when she found the strength to chip through Dezzolorth’s neckbone, but I’m pretty sure she still has no idea.”

“She faced more pressing distractions.”

Strolling around Ivan, not-so-subtly trying to follow his eyeline, Auro spotted nothing out of the ordinary. “It’s a fascinating study of magic. I’ve never before seen a summoned champion reject the magic that came with the role. How it will manifest when bonded to the summoner, that could be downright entertaining.”

“I’m not one for social games. If you want something, speak it plainly.”

Auro seemed to momentarily deflate a tad, before recovering his gusto. “Very well! In light of the fascinating development before my eyes, I would like to offer my services on your continuing quest. While your might is something to behold, I think I’ve proven that magic has its uses, too. Not to mention, the priestess will need a tutor for her growing capabilities.”

For a brief moment, Ivan’s eyes left the sky, meeting Auro’s for an instant. In that moment, however, he felt the tremendous weight of that man’s attention, the barely restrained power coursing through him.

“I said no games. You’re useful, I won’t deny that, but if you’re coming along, I have to know the real reason. Our original bargain is done. What’s actually pushing you forward?”

Ever so briefly, Auro debated spinning more yarns, but he was not a newly hatched serpent. There was a time for trickery and a time for truth; knowing the difference was what some might call wisdom. “These demons will be seeking out power at every turn—the more potent, the better. I’m still missing pieces of myself, each potent in its own right, with no idea where to start looking. Following you lets me relearn these lands, and

perhaps snap up some leads on making myself whole.” Pausing briefly, Auro felt his tongue try to hold back, forcing it to yield. “And because I’m lonely. I was in that swamp for a *very* long time.”

“Companionship and pieces of yourself.” Ivan nodded, his eyes once more skyward. “That’s a bargain I can honor, so long as conversation isn’t a required part of the deal.”

Auro’s eyes widened in shock, barely able to process what he’d just heard. “Was that... did you make a joke?”

“We just avenged a friend of mine and helped his niece onto a path that would have made him proud. I’m in a good mood.” Suddenly, a smile appeared on Ivan’s face. “One that just got better.”

With no more notice than that, Ivan was gone, vanished into thin air as he often did mid-battle. Auro scanned the courtyard to no avail, eventually shrugging and wandering over to check on Perle and Elya. They were, after all, now officially part of the same team.



Everything had been going so well until the strangers showed up. Zifgol had seen them coming since long before their arrival, warning Dezzolorth so that there was time to prepare. The stage was set for another easy victory... until it all fell apart. The way those people had cut through the demons and their allied humans, it was merciless, downright joyful in one case.

That was why Zifgol had hunkered away in a church’s bell tower, waiting until night fell and distraction took hold. More than anything, he had to pass along word of what had happened. Dezzolorth was a rising star among the demon ranks, but nowhere near the strongest of their number. His death would be a warning, a chance to ready themselves for a threat and perhaps even snuff it out early. But if these four were able to roam around posing as mere humans... no, Zifgol simply *had* to succeed.

When the night had freshly fallen, before the sky was lit with stars to betray his movements, Zifgol took off from his hiding place, wings snapping wide as he glided out into the night. Below him were the humans, scattered like livestock and just as easy to prey upon. Most of them, anyway. Zifgol gave the area one brief scan to make sure he wasn’t seen,

and to his horror found his eyes locking with a man on the ground. Not just any man, either.

Dezzolorth's killer was staring right at him. Then, he was gone, vanished from sight for a split second before Zifgol felt a powerful hand grab his neck, dragging him down onto a nearby rooftop. Zifgol attempted to struggle, swinging the claws of his right arm around and swiping. The arm was caught, then shattered, in a single motion. As the demon tried to cry out, he found a wet, gooey presence cutting off his words. When he realized exactly what the object was, Zifgol's struggling redoubled, not that it did any good.

Ivan was covering Zifgol's mouth with Dezzolorth's severed head. "You don't need to talk. Whatever threats you're going to give, offers you'll make, or pleading you'll try are all irrelevant. You're going to listen, and when I'm done, you'll take my message back to whoever is in charge. Nod once if you understand."

Much as Zifgol wanted to be proud and resist, he found his neck moving of its own accord. His survival instincts were screaming that this very well might be a one-time offer, and drops of Dezzolorth's cooled blood were already slipping down his throat, a fine reminder of where refusal led.

"Good. Then listen closely, because I don't intend to repeat myself."



The morning sun rose over a new Ravidon, one that had no corpses along its walls or demons lurking about. The town was mostly still sleeping off their night of celebration, relief, and terror over what came next. One of the exceptions was a group of four people loading up a cart with supplies.

Ravidon only had so much to spare, but they'd done their best to prepare Perle's party for the road. Grains, smoked meat, even a few satchels of fresh fruit. The donkey hitched to the front wasn't especially spry; however, it did have the benefit of not balking around Ivan or Auro, something none of the horses had been capable of. Whether it was pride, ignorance, or mere stubbornness, the donkey gave no reaction to either man, or any person at all. The aged beast moved when his carrot was presented, or not at all.

As Perle helped load their new wagon, she scanned the streets, eyes roaming the windows where she could feel stares peeking through. This *should* have been a celebration as well, a joyful farewell as they headed out to face more dangers. But that was the reception meant for heroes, and Perle felt quite far from that title.

The truth was, Ravidon was afraid of Perle, or at least the people who followed her. Grateful as they might be, Ivan and the others had effortlessly ripped apart the tormentors who'd kept these people subjugated for entire seasons. That kind of power was terrifying; one never knew when it could be turned in their direction. Add in that the priestess who was supposed to keep them controlled had instead executed a helpless demon... Perle didn't blame them for not turning out to say goodbye.

"That's the last barrel," Elya announced, walking around from the back. "Anything else to load up?"

"There had better not be," Auro whined, despite having hauled roughly the same amount as Perle.

Ivan shook his head. "That's the last of it."

Silence fell as, one by one, they looked to Perle. It was so preposterous; each of the three was a living weapon few could compare to, yet it was she who had to chart their course. She who had to decide what destination would be subjected to and saved by this strange group. She who would bear the burden of knowing that what came next happened at her behest.

Even a day later, she could still feel the weight of the sword in her hands, the sticky blood running down it. Whatever choice she made, there would be more blood spilled. Whether it was by her direct hand or not, it would lie upon her soul. The price of salvation was steep indeed, yet much as Perle wanted to refuse it, she couldn't. Not after seeing the town freed and the demons bested.

The fate of the world outweighed that of her soul. She had to believe that in order to do what was necessary. "We should make for Pravinia. It's one of the few truly free cities remaining, and where a great deal of the forces fighting the demons will have gathered. If anyone knows where to hit them and make it hurt, we'll find that information in Pravinia. But getting there will mean crossing through a good deal of demon-controlled territory."

Auro loudly smacked his lips, while Elya nodded. It was Ivan who spoke, asking what he no doubt saw as the most pertinent question. "Are we



to cross quietly, or otherwise?”

A whisper rose up from Perle’s mind, insisting she demand they take the stealthful route, make it to Pravinia, and then utilize the trio to inflict surprise wounds on the demon army. It was a pleasant notion, one she would never be able to actualize. Perle knew it would only take one demon-occupied village, a single terrified face, a mere cry for help, and she would act.

For too long, Perle had run around the world feeling powerless. Now, at last, she had the resources to fight back. No more running, no more hiding, no more hoping others would make the problems all go away. It was time for the demons to see how they liked being afraid.

“We save whoever needs saving, no matter how bloody our hands get,” Perle answered.

Slamming an armored fist into her open hand, Elya’s pleasure at the response was evident. “I knew that oracle wouldn’t steer me wrong.”

Auro grinned wide. “Excellent. After these last few days, I daresay I’m growing fond of the taste of wicked flesh. Certainly enough to sample more.”

Only Ivan crossed the divide between them, standing directly before her, his gaze like a physical weight on her shoulders. “Are you sure this is what you want?”

“No. I don’t want this at all, in fact,” Perle corrected. “But I’m the one who has the power to help, the opportunity to save so many people. It doesn’t matter what I want; it matters what I do.”

To her surprise, the smallest twinge of a smile tugged at Ivan’s lip for a brief moment. Then he was turned away, heading back toward the cart. Patting the donkey once, he waited as the animal strained against their loaded-down vehicle, struggling as it barely managed to get a few inches of movement.

With a very slight sigh, Ivan poked a single finger against the cart’s rear, pushing slightly. Their donkey surged forward, unprepared for the sudden burst of help, and with that, the party headed for Ravidon’s gates once more. Beyond those barriers lay a great deal more world to see, and perhaps, to save.

A world that had no idea what it was in store for.



“Go on.”

The voice carried easily through the chamber, cavernous as it was. Carved from golden stone, it had once been the throne room of an especially greedy king, one who had been happy to throw open his doors to the demons bearing gifts. Despite how the public portrayed the incident, it was the king who'd first broken their agreements, shaking down the demons for more and more gold as their efforts mounted. What began as a partnership swiftly soured, and now it was not the gold-loving king who sat on the throne, looking down at the battered demon kneeling. Instead, it was a figure covered entirely by a pitch-black cloak and hood.

Zifgol hurried to comply, the sense of danger palpable. Many demons were powerful and dangerous, hailing from realms that demanded such strength to survive. But the one seated on the throne was another matter. Covered entirely by a heavy cloak, this demon's reputation preceded them. The one who had gathered their fractured squabbles into a true army. Partly with charm, partly with reason, and helped substantially by overwhelming power.

“He told me that... that I should view him as the god of demons. A being beyond comprehension. That any demon he meets is expected to fall to their knees and beg for their lives. That...” Zifgol swallowed, fear of refusing to comply warring with what would happen if he spoke these next words aloud.

“Finish the message.”

Body spasming with terror, Zifgol forced his tongue to move, certain that death awaited any prolonged silence. “He said that he would tear down whatever pitiful excuse for a leader we had. That there was nothing in this world that could stand against him. That soon, we would all run from even the mention of a man called Ivan.” When death didn't descend after repeating such an insult, Zifgol relaxed ever so slightly.

Lifting his head, Zifgol froze in place as he saw something truly unprecedented. Their leader was leaning forward, the interest palpable. Doing so pulled back the hood of their cloak, revealing a strikingly handsome man with hair the color of burnished blood. He might have been mistaken for a human, if not for one key feature.

His eyes were like pits of shadow, brimming with darkness, save for the red runes burning in their center. An aching slow smile split his face as he stared at Zifgol, the gaze almost painful in its intensity.

“*What* was that name again?”

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# A VERY VILLAINOUS CHRISTMAS

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# I

Despite the sun still being out, Ivan had a roaring fire up in his condo.

Granted, that was largely because the flames were digital, presented on the flat-screen of the living room. In his true home, a real fire would be raging; however, that was currently being rebuilt thanks to an attack during the Ridge City Riots. Or, more accurately, Tori's enthusiastic defense from said attack, which had laser-carved a hole through the front of the home in the process.

That same woman was currently munching on a cookie fresh from the tray, paying the residual heat from the metal no mind. Being capable of transforming into living fire came up rarely in Tori's day-to-day, non-villain activities, but the fireproof aspect proved constantly handy.

"—and Beverly invited me to hang out with her family, but I didn't want to intrude. They only just patched things up a few months ago. I'm sure I'd find some way to spill her secrets or otherwise muck things up. Delicate social situations are not where I burn brightest."

Reaching out to snare another cookie while Ivan's back was turned, Tori had darted out of reach by the time he faced her once more, rolling his eyes. "At the rate you're going, I'll need to make a whole additional batch."

"Yeah, about that, did Beth's Starscout cluster decide to host a bake sale or something?" Tori motioned to the piles of cookies that were either baking, cooling, or carefully stored on plastic-wrapped plates. Ivan's daughter seemed the likeliest explanation for why her teacher was cooking so many sweets.

The baking itself wasn't odd, not to those who knew Ivan as the man he was rather than the terror-inspiring villain named Fornax. The guy loved

cooking, or at least eating, and had ample practice in the art. Rather, it was the abundance of pastries that stuck out. Even for Ivan's prodigious appetite, it was an excessive amount of cookies.

Given the day, a rogue thought slipped into Tori's mind, giving her a slight chuckle. "Or are you leaving all of these out, hoping to bribe Santa tonight?" It was late afternoon on Christmas Eve, so she felt obligated to make some manner of festive joke. What Tori wasn't expecting was for Ivan to fumble with his tray, even momentarily.

"Not Santa." That was all Ivan would say, adding an unexpectedly mysterious layer to what was supposed to be a friendly visit. Aside from her mid-October adventure, Tori had been hard at work since the Wrexwren invasion, getting her new line of products off the ground in time for the shopping season. So far, sales were going swimmingly.

As for Ivan, after having stepped onto a galactic stage and revealed that Fornax was alive, he'd elected to lay low for a while, giving the superheroes no pretense to come for him. Legendary villain or not, Fornax's criminal record had been wiped out over a decade prior, and there were currently no crimes he was charged with. If that changed, Tori wasn't sure what would happen, but she had a feeling it wouldn't be a good day for capes, villains, or the world as a whole.

A soft *thud* pulled Tori's focus to the living room, which was visible from Ivan's kitchen thanks to the open floor plan. Nothing there, but already Tori was up and moving, heat forming in her hands. Considering the powers possessed by people just within her social circle, she had no intention of dismissing potential invisible invaders that had made a crucial error. Ivan was moving on the other side of the counter, acting as a pincer to limit places an intruder could run.

Together, they advanced, ready to visit absolute hell on the poor unsuspecting soul that had picked the world's worst target for whatever crime they had in mind. Passing the TV, movement caught Tori's eye. Spinning to face the threat, she found herself staring at the digital fire—only, something had changed. Standing amidst the flames, and looking very unhappy about it, was a small figure in a brilliant green outfit. He had a white beard that was crisping at the edges as his tiny hands smacked against the glass.

Considering she was a member of a guild of villains and had several superhero and meta-human friends, Tori considered her threshold for weird

shit to be pretty damn high, but what was clearly an elf suddenly appearing in the fireplace on Ivan's television proved to be a step too far. "What the *fuck*?"

In seconds, Ivan was at her side, looking into the television screen as well. Unlike Tori, his reaction was that of a resigned sigh. Reaching out, he touched his hand to the glass. "This home welcomes the Messenger of the North."

Just like that, the elf's next strike to the screen sent him tumbling through the glass like it wasn't even there. He landed in a heap on the carpet, where Ivan scooped him up and carried the small man back into the kitchen. Selecting one of the cooled cookies, Ivan set it in front of the elf, who fell upon the morsel like a ravenous sugar-wolf.

As he ate, Tori noticed that the elf was recovering, the burned sections of his beard growing back and flush fading from his cheeks. He didn't stop until it was all gone, which was incredibly impressive considering that the treat was half his size. Only when their guest was finished did Ivan again speak.

"Twangle, what brings you here, and through such perilous avenues?"

Tori didn't even have time to be properly shocked that Ivan knew the intruding elf, or that his name was Twangle, before the reply was sputtering forth. "It was the only way I could get in! There's no real fireplace here, and you forgot to leave exceptions for those of the True North when you warded this place."

"Yes... forgot." Ivan broke off another piece of cookie and set it before Twangle, who kept munching, although at a more controlled pace than before. "And the reason?"

Twangle nearly spat out the mouthful of cookie he'd just gobbled, then swallowed it down at the last moment instead. "Trouble! Trouble in the True North. Trouble for the Night of Joy. A decree was given, the Guardian is needed. I was selected as the messenger."

To Tori's genuine shock, concern appeared on Ivan's face. "Bad enough to send someone before nightfall? All right, Twangle, tell me exactly what this trouble is."

"Shouldn't we go find the guardian he needs?" Tori could see what the situation was hinting at—even she wasn't capable of missing such obvious context clues—but her mind simply rebelled at the concept. There was no way, even for someone with as strange a life as Ivan.

Her certainty caved as Ivan showed uncharacteristic discomfort, idly rubbing at the back of his head. “We already have. Technically speaking... I am the Guardian of Christmas Magic.”

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## 2

Donald Moss had never seen the Alliance of Heroic Champions so bustling. Usually, when a major event happened, the capes were out on the streets, fighting to make things right. This evening, however, the entire compound was abuzz with activity. Hundreds of cargo containers were loaded down with various packages, each one vast enough to store thousands of parcels. Superheroes who could be seen flying through the air nightly were hunkered down, engaged in constant manual labor. No one could claim that they were too important for the task, not when the AHC's leadership was right there with them.

Professor Quantum was directing an army of drones to load his containers, the mechanical minions working in perfect harmony as they carefully filled each section like a flowing river. Quorum was hauling huge stacks of packages in each hand, balancing the precarious loads without any visible effort. As for Lodestar, she was literally a blur, zipping through the room and filling up her containers at inhuman speeds.

The blur blasted by his teammates; Ren, Lucy, and Irene were all in a line, helping to fill one of the seemingly endless containers. Donald would have been out there helping, too, except he'd been gathered with a different, smaller group of capes, though their number was still quite considerable.

"Okay, everyone, who knows why you're here tonight?" The words came from a man in an airline pilot's outfit; Avenging Aviator wasn't a huge name among capes, but he'd been around more than long enough to have earned a reputation for reliability. He chuckled at the hands that went up.

“Looks like we’ve got a few fellow former troublemakers in the mix. For the rest of you, a quick rundown. Tonight is the Alliance of Heroic Champions’ largest charity undertaking of each year. Most of the staff can only contribute in the preparatory stages, but you lot are different.”

Swinging his head around, Donald noticed that several of the other capes gathered had wings, jetpacks, or were literally floating off the ground as they listened to Avenging Aviator. Other heads swiveling about seemed to reach the same conclusions, and their speaker soon confirmed the suspicions.

“Among all of our ranks, you are the ones who can fly. Does anyone want to volunteer for a special task tonight? There’s room for everyone we can get, and I can promise it’s an experience like no other.”

Every hand gathered went up, because this was not a grouping of random people with powers. It was a collection of superheroes, beings who’d devoted themselves to helping others with the gifts they’d been given. One tidbit that Donald did notice, though, was that the hands that went up fastest were also the ones who already knew what they were doing.



Western Ridge Mall sat nestled on the northern end of Ridge City, much to the consternation of anyone seeking it without GPS and those who had any sense of directional propriety. Bodies were crammed thick into the halls as last-minute shopping frantically occurred. It was the sort of place where Beverly wanted nothing more than to shift into her green dragon form and start throwing elbows, but her younger cousins would probably take the wrong lessons from such a display.

Sebastian and Ansel were teetering between excitement and terror as they waited in the long line that snaked out a considerable distance. Her family had tasked Beverly with getting them out of the house while everyone else readied the decorations and festivities. She remembered her own childhood, the magical sensation of leaving a fairly normal-looking home, only to return to find merriment hanging from every wall. It was a tradition she loved, even if it did drag her to a crowded mall on Christmas Eve.

At least they were getting near the front of the line, finally. Sebastian was growing steadily more worried, while Ansel was putting on a brave face. As the older of the boys, Ansel had met with a mall Santa the year before, and wanted to show his little brother that everything would be okay. A loud, deep laugh rumbled through the mall from within Santa's workshop, tickling something in Beverly's brain.

The laugh was obviously theatrical, put on for the benefit of the kids, yet it was also oddly familiar. She kept analyzing the sound, trying to place it, but never quite managing. Tens of minutes dragged by as they plodded along the final stretch of line, at long last reaching the front kiosk where a tall man with dirty-blond hair was waiting. He was clad in a bright green elf costume, complete with curly shoes and a hat with a bell.

Gazing on his face, Beverly's eyes widened and her heart started to hammer in her chest. Of all the people from the guild she could encounter out in the world like this, he was the last one she'd expected. Being part of an association of villains meant keeping some unsavory company, and while the man before her might be among the most moral of the lot, he was also counted as one of the scariest.

"Welcome to Santa's Workshop," Kristoph greeted, his tone pleasant and soothing. At the sound of his voice, Ansel and Sebastian both visibly relaxed, fear slowly slipping away. He met her eyes, the recognition evident, yet no word of their association passed his lips. "Would you two like to meet with Santa as a group, or one at a time?"

"Together," Sebastian whispered, and Ansel took his little brother's hand, nodding in agreement.

"Then my fellow elf will guide you to the enchanted lands of Santa's Workshop."

From within the picturesque cottage, sounds of movement could be heard, the only warning before the door flew open and another elf bounded enthusiastically out into the fake snow. "I heard we have two more visitors that braved the perils of the North Pole to come meet with Santa."

If seeing Kristoph had given Beverly pause, the sight before her stopped the woman in her tracks. Surely, it was a trick. Some scheming crook had decided to take on a member of the guild and had trapped her in some sort of ridiculous illusion. That felt *far* more logical than seeing the villain known as Johnny Three Dicks strolling around in an elf ensemble identical to Kristoph's.

That loud laugh rang out once more, and with the sight of Johnny Three Dicks right before her, Beverly was finally able to place it. Despite putting on a fake Santa voice, she could now recognize the laugh of her mentor in the guild, a muscular man who went by Thuggernaut.

Taking a deep breath, Beverly plastered on a smile and ushered her cousins forward, all the while haunted by one all-consuming thought.

Why the fuck were three supervillains running a mall Santa stand?

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### 3

“I don’t even know where to start with something that nuts.” Tori sat on the couch, next to Twangle, who was sipping cocoa from a mug much too large for him, rubbing at the sides of her head. “Santa is real? And apparently has Christmas magic, which needs a guardian, a job that somehow landed *you* in the role.”

Choking down a clump of half-melted marshmallows, Twangle spoke up. “Twas an eve before Christmas, and all through the night, danger was lurking, hidden just out of sight—”

“Thank you, Twangle, but since you seem to be in a hurry, I’ll handle the explanation. Goes faster without the rhyming.” Ivan set a plate of cookies down on the coffee table between them, and before Tori could blink, the elf had one in each hand, mug resting in his lap. How had he even reached that far?

Settling down in a chair himself, Ivan continued. “First, the issue of Santa himself. He is certainly real, though none of us are quite sure of the means by which that became so. The being is shaped by our collective beliefs: he lives at the North Pole, flies through the air using reindeer, and works with elves like Twangle here. Whether he is formed by some mysterious collective magic of the unconscious, is a meta of top-tier power living out a specific fantasy, was willed into being by a reality-warper with a knack for permanence, or some yet unconsidered option, the fact remains that he exists.”

Chomping through both cookies in wide-mouthed bites, Twangle nodded in agreement, cheeks swollen with crumbs.

“Additionally, Santa commands a tremendous amount of magical power. Most of which is harnessed for his yearly run. That said, so much power inevitably draws other mystical beings, ones who want to steal, feed on, or otherwise corrupt the magic to their own ends. Hence why it requires a guardian. As to how that ended up being me... a malicious entity believed Fornax would be the key to toppling Santa and enlisted my aid. When I found the situation was not what I’d been promised, I showed my displeasure by switching sides and ruining the plan entirely.”

Slowly, Tori started to nod. “Okay, spite as a motivator, I get. Sorry, just took me by surprise. I figured the gig would go to someone like Lodestar.”

“The heretic!” Twangle spat the word out, along with a generous spray of cookie, like it burned his tongue.

Ivan winced, looking at the half-chewed confectionary now spread across his floor. “Forgot to warn you, try not to bring her up if possible. Lodestar and Santa don’t have the best relationship.”

“Wait, hold the fuck on. Someone has beef with Santa Claus, and that person is Lodestar? Unstoppable, World’s Greatest Superhero, all-that-shit Lodestar?”

“World’s *only* true superhero,” Ivan corrected. “But yes, that Lodestar. I’ll explain later. For now, let’s just say that she and Santa have philosophical differences and leave it there. Twangle, now that Tori is up to speed, why don’t you tell me what brings you to my... fireplace this evening?”

With a determined set of his spine, Twangle tilted the mug up and drained the rest of its contents—no small feat given his size in ratio to the amount of liquid consumed. Properly braced, he set the cup down and began.

“Started with a toy. Someone sent Santa a toy, of all things! Touched he was, thought the notion so sweet. Put it up on a shelf in a place of honor in the workshop. But things started going wrong. Toy trucks driving through the walls of playhouses. Dollies found around the remains of stuffed animals. Mechanical trains sent crashing off the tracks by hidden traps. Then we saw it, the toys were moving! Moving on their own, no batteries or wind-ups, no strings or pulleys or tricks, or—”

“Twangle.” Ivan said the word softly, yet it was enough to halt the elf’s rant, bringing him back to the topic at hand.

“Winterward is the oldest elf. He said magic came in on the toy, but isn’t only there now. Evil spirit, uses toys as bodies, has been growing stronger since reaching the True North. Spirit must be purged. Many potential toys are compromised. If spirit isn’t stopped, houses will be missed, and the Christmas Spirit will suffer greatly.”

Suddenly jerking up her head, Tori looked at Ivan with fresh curiosity. “Wait, is there actually a spirit of Christmas, like some looming specter? Oh, or three of them that show up to torment rich assholes?”

“One metaphysical revelation per night tends to be a good rule,” Ivan counseled, not at all denying what Tori had mostly meant as a joke. His focus shifted back to Twangle, who’d snagged another cookie in the brief pause. “Let me guess, the reason none of your own wards are working is because the spirit is using toys, which the workshop’s magic is designed to protect.”

Standing up, Ivan released an incredibly drawn-out sigh before exiting the room. He returned less than a minute later, holding a small wooden box with an intricately designed carving along the top. It was of a tree, yet the detail was so real that Tori could feel the pine needles against her skin, smell its sap wafting over the cold mountain air that in no way should have been permeating Ivan’s condo.

He touched the gleaming latch, which sprang open, as did the box itself. It parted to reveal a lush green interior, upon which rested a single silver bell with a handle that resembled volcanic glass. A coppery tang joined the smell of pine, the sharp scent of air just before a snowstorm.

“With apologies, Tori, I’m afraid this is a duty that I cannot shirk. Deals were made, and debts must be honored.”

“Ivan, I hope you don’t think you’re dropping all this shit on my lap and then bouncing. You can’t just say Santa is real and in danger then expect me to go watch *Justice Hound Saves Christmas* or whichever classic old flick they’re playing tonight. Whatever you’re about to do, I am so fucking in.”

It was roughly the outcome he’d expected, knowing his apprentice. “There’s nothing wrong with enjoying the classics, but very well. The North Pole is generally a safe place, especially for one with your training. However, if I tell you to fall back, do it quickly. Magical dangers can prove extremely surprising, and you’ll be without a meta-suit.”

Picking up the bell from within the box, Ivan rang it a single time. Wind whipped against Tori’s side; the gleaming silver archway that had appeared

in Ivan's living room was letting in one hell of a draft. Through it, she could see a dense forest of massive trees, as well as the soft glow of light coming just over a snowdrift.

Twangle hopped up from the couch and bolted through, Tori following several steps behind. Setting the bell down on the table, Ivan went through last, the archway vanishing seconds after he'd passed its threshold.

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# 4

“You look handsome tonight.” Xelas reached out and adjusted Wade’s bowtie, for all the good it did. There was an inherent rumpled-ness to the man that never fully faded, regardless of how pressed and proper his outfit was. With his thinning copper hair and aging appearance, he looked like little more than the billionaire tech mogul the world knew him to be. So few realized that beneath the placid, crowd-pleasing genius he displayed lurked a mind of true intellect.

Xelas herself was one such exception; it was getting to know the true Wade that had first sparked her attraction. Her form was reflected in the mirror behind him; tonight, she’d chosen to appear as a lovely brunette clad in a sparkling red-and-green dress. Being out with Wade, rather than Doctor Mechanial, meant blending in with the humans. Once, it had felt smothering, but the freedom to choose her own form turned such transformations into just another type of fashion. Xelas changed faces like earrings, selecting whatever suited her best in the moment.

“As if anyone will have a single glance to spare me with such a vision on my arm.” Wade offered his elbow to Xelas, which she accepted, the two walking out of the dressing room. A pair of muscular bodyguards were waiting just outside. Though they appeared human, both were in fact robots being operated by Xelas. Human guards had proven too vulnerable, both to treachery and assault, so they’d long ago switched to automated options.

“How’s the take so far?”

“We crested twenty million a few moments ago. I expect that, before the night is done, we’ll breach fifty,” Wade reported. It sounded like a lot of

money, to someone who wasn't able to access all of Indigo Technologies' accounts.

The holographic face of Xelas pinched in frustration. "Fifty million. You know we could write that check ourselves and not even feel the hit? Any one of these rich bastards could fund the whole charity, and a dozen others like it, just on a whim. But for this whole fancy event, weeks of work and coordinating, they're barely pitching in a few million apiece. Humans truly are the fucking worst."

"Would that I could disagree, but even I stand here for much the same self-serving reason. It is not the support of those in need which drives us, rather the act of being seen giving such support. We all use the positive coverage to hide away our darker enterprises. After all, who would suspect Wade Wyatt, noted philanthropist, to ever resort to something as base as theft?" The smile on his lips seemed subdued, unless one caught the spark of mischief in his eyes.

That was what had sealed the deal for Xelas's affections. Composed as Wade appeared on the outside, he was just as wicked, petty, and cruel as the rest of his species. Yet he made no efforts to deny such impulses; instead, he chose to focus them carefully, selecting targets deserving of such treatment. The twisted mix of animosity and empathy that made humans such fascinating beings took a shape in him that she found called to her.

At the end of the hall waited more guards and a pair of reinforced doors. One of the benefits of playing host was that Wade got some privacy to prepare in, plus the chance to make an entrance. Whether as Doctor Mechaniacal or Wade Wyatt, he always loved his entrances. "Ready, my darling?"

"Already scanning."



"Are you sure we put out enough cookies for Santa?" Penelope squirmed in her bed, wiggling to stay awake despite the way her eyelids kept drooping downward.

"I think a full dozen is more than enough. He has to leave room for the other kids' cookies, too," Helen assured her.

When the container packing was mostly done, Lodestar had slipped away briefly before the night's real work began, turning back into Helen upon reaching her home. This was her first time making the trip since Penelope had been born; it was impossible during the years she spent not using her powers.

Helen felt fairly sure she was more nervous about leaving her daughter than Penelope, who seemed much more concerned with Santa's arrival. To the child's credit, she had a known family friend watching over her, so perhaps the situation didn't seem all that strange. A pang of guilt echoed through Helen's heart; she'd had to leave Penelope more and more lately as Lodestar was called upon.

That was why she took her time getting Penelope ready for bed. They got the cookies and milk ready, picked out reindeer pajamas, and read several Christmas stories before the tucking in commenced. It was a slice of normalcy, a reminder of what really mattered. Tomorrow, Helen planned to spend the entire day with her daughter. Lodestar would be well due for a break after what the night entailed.

Despite Penelope's best efforts, sleep soon seized hold of her, the heavy eyelids drifting all the way down. Helen stayed in the room for a while yet, watching her child sleep, wondering when it was she'd gotten so big. It felt like mere days ago Penelope had easily fit in her hands, so impossibly tiny and delicate. Leaning down, Helen kissed her daughter's forehead, brushing the pajamas' costume antlers out of the way.

Out in the hall, Teresa was waiting. A longtime friend and neighbor, few people knew that the older woman was a meta, let alone that she could produce shields of incredible power. "Thank you for watching her, again. I'm sorry to depend on you so much lately."

"Please, she's a joy, and the extra income has been a big help. Besides which, you, of all people, do not need to apologize about asking for help." It was roughly the same reaction Teresa had given to all of Helen's apologies.

"Still, it's important you know how much I appreciate you," Helen reiterated, earning a smile from the usually stoic woman.

"Consider me suitably mollified, unless you'd like to rest a bit longer. Then I can protest and make you do a few more rounds of compliments."

Tempting as that sounded, Helen shook her head. There would be plenty of time for rest tomorrow. "Love to, but I've got a long night ahead of me."

In a blur of light, she was gone, leaving a tray with eleven cookies sitting atop the counter and a trail of crumbs leading to the door.

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# 5

A world of twinkling lights stretched out before Tori. From atop their snowbank, she could see the entire village, hidden away by the huge rifts of snow in all directions, like it was at the bottom of a frosty bowl. Small houses dotted the edges, leading to a large apartment complex, which was close to a series of ten enormous warehouses. A sizable mansion rested toward the rear, but in the village's center lay the largest building by far. Brick, huge, and with a steady flow of Twangle-sized bodies flowing in and out, Tori could only presume that to be the legendary workshop.

"What the living shit," she muttered, gazing in shock at the hidden world before a gust of wind tore through her. In seconds, she was shivering, tapping into her own internal heat and raising it up. Since she had fire-based powers, cold was her natural enemy. Fending it off took constant effort, and when she exhausted herself, Tori would be vulnerable.

"Naughty language," Twangle scolded.

"Well, excuse me. I'm still grappling with the fact that apparently Santa C-C-Claus is not only real, but has a world-famous villain on whatever the elf-version of speed-dial is called." Despite attempts at warming up, Tori couldn't quite keep the chatter from her teeth.

Ivan studied her, then shook his head. "I'd forgotten how bad the cold is. Twangle, before anything else, we need to get Tori some cocoa."

"But Winterward said—"

"I have answered the summons and agreed to the task. That does not mean I will permit my guest to suffer." Ivan stared down at the elf, who held his own for a surprisingly long amount of time before finally looking down.

Before either could speak, a cacophony of cheers rose from deeper in the village. Clapping, yelling—it was like someone had just scored a game-winning touchdown at the final moment. From behind the mansion’s rear, a shape appeared, soaring up into the sky. Eight horned quadrupeds in rows, with a ninth up front, all pulling a sleigh that was easily the brightest red Tori had ever seen. Up and up the shape rose, before blasting off at incredible speed, vanishing from sight in under a second.

She stared up at the sky even after it was gone, dumbfounded. Being a scientist in a world where the laws of physics were more like guidelines and magic itself was proven to be real was always a tall task, but watching Santa Claus take off from the North Pole still pushed against her limits of plausibility.

If Tori weren’t being led by an elf and a man who could tear into steel like she could a bag of chips, it might have taken longer to recover; thankfully, the flipside to living around impossible things was the rapidity with which one learned to adjust.

“Isn’t it-t-t a little early for Santa to t-t-take off? We’d barely hit dusk back in Ridge C-C-City.”

“Night doesn’t begin there,” Ivan reminded her. Hearing her increased chatter, he picked up the pace, Twangle and Tori doing the same.

They soon arrived at one of the entrances to the enormous factory. Twangle led them through without pause, though Tori noticed the other elves all staring. At first, she thought it was the fact that she and Ivan towered over everyone else present, but she soon realized that no one was sparing her a second glance. Every gaze was on Ivan. Stranger still was the way they looked at him. Not with fear, terror, anger, or hate, as a villain of his caliber usually encountered when his power was known. No, if anything, the elves appeared downright reverent.

The halls of the factory were brightly colored, with festive décor added wherever possible. Garlands ran along the rafters, tinsel wove through handrails, and ornaments adorned anything that would support them, mostly lighting fixtures. While Tori was feeling better with the wind no longer cutting through her, the chill in the air still persisted, causing her occasional shivers.

At last, Twangle led them to a circular room with the scent of food wafting out. It appeared as if someone had set up a buffet for Christmas dinner, only with seventy-five percent focused on dessert. While there was

indeed some ham, stuffing, potatoes, and other classics, they had nothing on the tables of pies, rows of cakes, and absolute decadence of cookies. It was none of these that stopped Twangle's progress, though. He didn't halt until he'd reached a silver kettle with matching cups lined up alongside it.

Ivan reached down, pouring a cup for himself, Twangle, and Tori. The cups were comically small in their human hands, making Ivan look a tad ridiculous as he took a tentative sip from the silver container. Still, the cocoa smelled good and felt warm, so Tori tossed hers back as well.

The first impression to strike her was the taste. Rich, deep, and just the right amount of sweet, she felt as if she'd taken a swig of the proto-cocoa from which all lesser imitations sprang. What she noticed next, however, was the warmth. It grew from her stomach, stretching out through her limbs, all the way to her skin. In seconds, the persistent chill was gone; Tori may as well have been standing in Ivan's condo again, she was so comfortable.

"Whoa."

"They do make the good stuff, even setting aside the magical properties," Ivan agreed, refilling everyone's cup. Twangle had drained his with the same enthusiasm as his larger companions. "It'll only last for tonight, but you should find that the cold here is no longer an issue. Meaning we can get down to business. Twangle, if you will."

Since the elf in question had another mouthful of cocoa, he nearly spat it upon hearing his name, but managed to switch to a sudden gulp instead. "Yes! Yes! Time to act. Must hurry, we must, for the night has begun."

Tugging on Ivan's hand, he pulled him back into the hallways, explaining as they went. "All toys that were possibly possessed were moved to one warehouse. Winterward said we had to contain the threat. Spirit is trapped now, but the warehouse was already so full. Santa won't risk delivering a toy that could hurt someone. If the toys aren't purged in time, Santa won't use any from that warehouse, and countless good children will awaken to a lesser Christmas than they deserved."

"So, to fight some malevolent entity that can possess toys, you're sending us into a warehouse full of them?" Tori noted. "Not to mention, we *just* watched Santa fly away; how is he supposed to be delivering presents from the warehouses here?"

"Magic bag that pulls presents as needed," Ivan explained with a bored tone, as if it were obvious. "And our situation is even worse than you think:

we'll have to handle the spirit while restraining ourselves. Wouldn't do to wreck the very toys we're trying to protect," Ivan reminded her.

"Shit. I should have taken more of that cocoa as payment."

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## 6

“—So I finished my loading shift and headed on over. Kyle is getting prepped for a delivery shift, whatever that entails, and Ellie went to do some volunteer work. They’re holding up okay. I can see it in their faces when we get into costume, though. Part of them is still waiting for you to make a bad joke or awkward innuendo, and when it doesn’t come, that’s when they remember.”

The muscular man with shoulder-length blond hair tipped back his bottle of beer, a matching one resting unopened on the headstone. There was no body in the grave, but lacking a way to visit the cold depths of space, Austin had to settle for the resting place they had.

Ike’s grave was lovely, situated between a pair of shady trees that had currently lost all their foliage, instead burdened with drifts of recent snow. Austin sat on the cold ground, his meta-human body unbothered by such a mundane annoyance. Just like the beer would do nothing against his enhanced constitution. He was a man gifted with strength far beyond what most could hope for.

Yet it still hadn’t been enough. Every day since Presto died, laying down his life to save the rest of the team from a threat they couldn’t beat, Austin had replayed the battle in his mind. As Agent Quantum, was there anything else he might have done, a single move that would have changed the outcome? And each day, he reached the same conclusion: no. Nothing he did would have mattered; the gulf between his power and their enemy’s was too great.

“I picked out some sweaters for Kyle and Ellie, then got extras for Tori, Beverly, and Chloe, too. I’ll never understand why, of all things, you

actually liked Christmas, enough to even start a tradition. Seemed like it would be too gooey or sentimental for you. Just goes to show what I know.”

Austin picked at the label on his beer bottle, tugging away the corner. “The truth is, I never really understood you, Ike. Lord knows I tried, but you and I, we just think... thought in different ways. I’m sorry for that. I know you always felt like a tacked-on part to the team, and I never found a way to break through to show you how wrong that was. Because you *were* integral, and these last few months have only made that clearer than ever. I wish... I wish I’d found a way to show you how much you mattered to us all, before it was too late.”

With a few final glugs, Austin finished off his beer, tucking the bottle into a canvas bag at his side. It would hardly be proper for a member of the New Science Sentries to litter. Letting out a light grunt, he rose to his feet, looking the grave over once more.

“I’ve got to head off, told Ellie I’d meet up with her soon to help with the volunteer work. If you were there, I’m sure you’d be spiking people’s soup with candy-cane vodka or something. I’ll see if I can think of a way to add levity in your honor, though we both know it won’t be the same.” Reaching over, he popped the lid off the gravestone beer and tipped it onto its side, allowing the suds to gently pour onto the ground.

“One day, I’m going to bring your body back and lay you to proper rest. I promise.” Tapping the headstone once, Austin trudged off, his heavy form leaving deep footprints in the graveyard snow.



Working a grill was supposed to be hot, but that was for people who didn’t regularly channel plasma through their body and send it searing through the air. To Ellie, who the world thought of as Plasmodia when covered in her costume, the grill’s heat was barely even noticeable as she turned another row of bacon.

“How’s it going over here?” Chloe popped by to check in, as she had been since they first arrived. “Belinda sent me to grab the next batch and ask if you needed any help.”

“It’s busy, but I’m managing,” Ellie answered. When Chloe had asked if anyone was interested in joining up for an evening of volunteer work, Ellie

had imagined ladling soup in a rundown old building. As a new Ridge City transplant, she wasn't aware that a coalition of downtown businesses came together and put on an outright Christmas feast for the local unhoused and transient population.

It was, of course, done with lots of cameras in place; the footage would be a key factor in making sure the businesses wrung every drop of social goodwill possible out of their good deeds. Ellie expected it would pop up in the next year's ads, but she couldn't deny that at least good work was being accomplished.

Dozens of tables were already filled with people eating, and the line to enter seemed like it was only growing with every passing moment. Checking around, making sure there was no one besides Chloe near, Ellie waved a hand over the searing bacon, releasing a soft burst of plasma in the process. The half-cooked strips of pork were suddenly crisp and seared, allowing Ellie to scoop them onto a plate which she handed over to Chloe.

"Let Belinda know I'll have the next round ready to go as quick as possible." Ellie looked out at the crowd again, wincing as she waited for Ike to make an inappropriate joke she'd need to apologize for. When one didn't come, she felt the absence, as she had every moment like this in the months since Ike's death. They didn't hurt as much as they used to, though that only made Ellie feel worse overall. She wanted the pain to stay fresh. Anything less felt like she was letting his memory slip away.

Chloe nodded, accepting the plate. "I'm glad you found a rhythm before things got too hectic. As the night wears on, expect to see a lot more people."

"I'm a little surprised at the turnout, truthfully. Ridge City doesn't have a lot of people camped out on the streets. I'd never expected so many to be in hard situations." Ellie could scarcely recall a panhandler when making their patrols, let alone so many lacking a home.

"Part of the trade-off for having the AHC in our backyard," Chloe explained. "Superheroes mean super battles, leading to a lot of property destruction. As part of their recompense, the AHC funds housing programs to make sure everyone has a warm bed and healthy food, whether you're down on your luck or a madman riding a robot pterodactyl ripped your family's condo in half. They don't put on a spread like this, though, hence the turnout."

All around them, delicious smells rose from the various cooking stations rolled out by downtown restaurants. Some had even mobilized their food trucks, making sure to get good placement in the cameras' sight lines, creating a smorgasbord of delectable options.

"That's certainly generous of them. I guess you must know all about the system, having worked this event before."

"You've got the order flipped around," Chloe corrected. "I know about this event because I've been through the housing systems. That robot pterodactyl? It wasn't hypothetical."

Taking the bacon, Chloe hurried off to a woman conducting an entire section of the outdoor kitchen, her flour-coated apron letting off small white clouds as she whirled about. Ellie focused on the task at hand, adding a fresh round of bacon to her grill. One of these days, she really needed to sit and chat with Chloe; the woman had a fascinating life, especially for someone without powers.

The warehouse felt like a child's dreamland, if one had possessed a particularly grand sense of scale. Toys lined every wall in all manner of shapes and configuration: stuffed animals, remote cars, wooden train sets, action figures, bouncy balls, and so many more. It felt stuffed to the gills, like every shelf was a single candy cane away from exploding outward, the space unable to contain a molecule more. And there was a preposterous amount of shelves, climbing all the way to the high ceiling and running the entire length of the building.

"I'd call this a needle-in-a-haystack situation, but I'd fucking kill for those odds comparatively." Tori motioned to the vast expanse just beyond the warehouse doors, shut tightly behind them after entering. It was presumably to seal the evil spirit inside, though Tori did notice that meant locking them in, too, a fact which didn't seem to bother Twangle one bit. She hoped it was because of his faith in Ivan, and not a total apathy toward their well-being.

"It's not so bad as all that," Ivan replied, striding down the rows and rows of shelves, eyes darting about. "Wielding magic means I've got a sense for it, which should help me seek out our target, though I admit this whole building is permeated with its power. Besides, you're ignoring our greatest advantage."

"Which is?"

"We're not just hunting the needle; the needle is hunting us, as well. Should make it much easier to find."

It spoke a great deal about Ivan's general mindset that a magical malevolent entity coming after him was seen as an advantage, rather than a

terrifying danger. Tori stayed close, not eager to try her luck against such a foe. Potent a weapon as fire could be, magic was unpredictable, and she didn't want to find out this spirit considered it pleasantly warming.

Together, they combed through the warehouse one row at a time, walking up and down the length of it, waiting for Ivan's senses to trip or a toy to lunge out at them. There was only silence, save for the occasional gust of wind roaring outside the walls. Up and down the rows they went, until the toys were more multi-colored blobs in Tori's eyes than individual shapes. When they turned the corner to yet another row, Tori expected more mundanity.

Instead, they found an army waiting. Plastic soldiers whose weapons looked unexpectedly real, toy cars producing smoke as they revved their engines, stuffed rabbits with wild eyes and sharp teeth, on and on it went through the whole row, columns of toys all lined up and eager for the attack.

Tori had half-formed a fireball on instinct when Ivan grabbed her shoulder. "Remember, minimal damage. Each of these toys is intended for someone. Every one we break steals from their joyful morning."

"Ivan, I've watched you genocide an entire army without batting an eye. These things look hungry for blood, and you want us to hold back?"

He merely shrugged. "Deals were made, and debts must be honored. While here, I am acting in my role as Guardian. So yes, we hold back. Destroy only what is absolutely necessary. If we resist long enough, I'm quite sure the true spirit will show itself."

Stepping forward into the row of shelves, it was as if Ivan had sounded a starter pistol. Like a surging river, the army flowed toward him, moving in perfect coordination. Tori watched in wonder as they stormed onto him, stabbing and slashing, swinging and smashing. None of it mattered, of course. He was the man once called Fornax, a meta-human whose only defeat was to the superhero who never lost, even against giant, star-eating monsters spawned from the cosmos. Hitting him was causing the toys more damage than anything.

Realizing that they were supposed to be limiting just that, Tori thought fast, then fired off a couple of fireballs into the air, making sure to aim away from the shelves. "Hey, you misfit-aisle fucks, there's two of us here. Do I need to *make* you see me as a threat?" She shot off another fireball, this

time directly over the charging army. It flew down the row, illuminating just how far back the waiting river of toys truly ran.

The damage was done, however, as part of the flowing toys split off, moving toward Tori. She responded by shifting into fire-form and floating up into the air. Though her natural flight lacked the speed and maneuverability of her meta-suit, Tori hoped it would be adequate to the task of keeping her out of harm's reach. Even if one did manage to hop up and attack her, it would only deform the plastic of their weapon. The stuffed animals would be in for a worse time, admittedly, but there was no such thing as a perfect plan.

A fact Tori was swiftly reminded of as she heard the sounds of blades cutting through air. Flying toward her were a squadron of remote-controlled helicopters, and from their supposedly plastic guns came a hail of tiny, yet quite real, bullets. They flew harmlessly through Tori, who, as living flame, was largely immune to such mundane strikes. Sadly, the same couldn't be said for the toys attacking her.

In the initial round of firing, the helicopters took down three stuffed rabbits, a child-sized doll with a porcelain face, and nearly a dozen plastic soldiers. Ivan was already past the helicopters, wading slowly and carefully through the assault as he ignored their blows, so he wouldn't be much help. Tori could risk a wide blast to bring them all down, but that would come with serious collateral damage.

Instead, she opted to make use of her airborne abilities, flying over the heads of the toys as she fled from the helicopters. They could fire at her all day; she just needed to find an angle where the bullets wouldn't hit the other toys as well. Soaring about, steering with controlled blasts of flame, Tori raced back through the rows they'd checked, leading her pursuers to waste their shots against the floor and ceiling.

It was more fun than she'd expected, a dance in the air. There was something instinctual about flying under her own power, the movements more natural than in her suit, allowing her to get lost in the joy of motion.

A dark paw the size of a frying pan suddenly swatted at her from the shadows. Tori saw the blow coming, but there wasn't time to dodge, so she could only say a silent apology to the stuffed animal about to immolate itself on her. Rather than pass harmlessly through her, however, the blow connected, sending Tori spiraling back through the air before splashing on the ground.

As she reformed her flames to a humanoid shape, Tori watched her attacker fully emerge. It was a stuffed bear, if the bear in question was a grizzly. Taller than Ivan, wide as Thuggernaut, and with claws that looked like kitchen knives, this stuffed bear would send a real one running for the hills. And worst of all, it had just proven able to hit Tori, even in her fire-form.

Rising back up, Tori's flames flared, burning significantly hotter. "Damn, do I hate magic."

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## 8

**B**lasts from the pulse cannon roared through the air, tearing holes in the clouds even as that damnable sleigh veered and whipped about. The laws of physics had been famously turned to suggestions since Professor's Quantum experiment all those decades ago, yet even those flimsy foundations were being flaunted as the sleigh changed directions without warning, all inertia ignored as its pilot darted out and scurried down a chimney.

Once, there would have been traps installed and waiting: shredding blades, searing flames, crackling bolts of specialized energy. None of which would work, as she'd learned through the years, hence why such implements were no longer mandatory for all citizens to have installed. That, and the fact that her feud was mostly sheer tradition at this point.

Tyranny stared out from her balcony, the cameras in her body-encompassing suit easily able to parse the assault's details. There was a time when her efforts to smite that incarnation of trespassing magic were quite genuine; she would spend weeks every year scheming up new ways to breach those mystical protections. Such rage had run through her, at the interloper daring to stand upon her lands without its ruler's permission. Time and experience—the experience of one particularly well-labeled Christmas present, to be precise—had weathered away much of her animosity toward the man in the red.

Nevertheless, Tyranny had issued a proclamation, and she would not be seen as one who so easily capitulated. So it was that every year, the citizens of Indroga gathered below to watch as the sky burst with color from the

pulse cannons. They laughed and cheered as Santa nimbly avoided capture, all while still completing his rounds.

Vendors in the streets sold hot dishes alongside Christmas classics. Her island nation had developed a more communal celebration of the holiday than many practiced, in no small part because of the annual artillery fire that accompanied his visit. None feared a stray shot or falling debris; whatever allegations one could make toward the meta named Tyranny, she never suffered from a lack of precision.

Footsteps came from the floor behind her, metal-bottomed boots that clanged heavily off the reinforced marble floor. Tyranny had no need to turn and see who approached; the cameras throughout her castle—her island as a whole, really—fed her the information from a dozen different angles. Besides which, there was only one person on the entire island who would dare stroll up casually to her side, even if he did bring a tall glass of eggnog as an offering.

“Just finished my first batch. Wanted you to have the inaugural taste.”

One of Tyranny’s metal-covered hands accepted the drink, showing far more delicacy than its brutalist design might imply. Sensors scanned the chemical compound, hunting for poisons and other foreign elements automatically, not that she waited for their report. Tyranny trusted no one, never had, until this sole exception arrived in her life. Opening a hatch along her helmet with a thought, she sipped gently from the brim, nodding in approval.

“Outstanding. Somehow, it gets better every year.”

He smiled, genuine joy running through those familiar features. “*Someone* instilled in me a drive to always be tinkering, trying to make things the best they can be, and then improve on that again.”

“What a fine teacher, to offer such a priceless lesson,” Tyranny complimented.

“That she is. Anyway, I’m going to dole up some cups of these to those on break, then take a squad up so we can harass Santa as he’s making his exit. It’s weird how much they love seeing us pretend to drive him off.”

“The masses always love a victor; it is why they are content in my care.” Tyranny took another sip of her eggnog, a homemade product worlds superior to anything found in a store. It was hard to believe that Christmas had once been her most hated of holidays.

Her visitor nodded, smiling once more. “Well, then I’ll go make sure they’ve got a win to cheer about for the coming year.” Before leaving, the man wrapped his arms around the enormous mechanical suit in which the woman called Tyranny dwelled. He squeezed hard, but she was beyond durable, and his efforts couldn’t even manage a dent, not that he’d been trying.

“Merry Christmas, Mom. I’ll swing by with another glass after we send Santa packing.”



Art without purpose was chaos. Despite what many, *many*, ignorant critics had speculated through the years, Captain Bullshit was not an agent of chaos. He used chaos, certainly, as a tool upon the medium of reality, but that no more made him an agent of chaos than a sculptor was an agent of clay. And chaos was but one brush in his satchel. Creating grandiose experiences required so much more. There was order, timing, humor, drama, overtiness, unvertiness—and outright vertiness itself, if he was feeling especially daring.

His pieces were meant to invoke a sensation of the spectacular, to rouse the sense of wonder from the cage of routine. Yet on Christmas Eve, the air already crackled with magic. Great moments big and small were occurring on their own, the occasion significant enough to force many from their ruts, bringing the wonder of surprise to friends and loved ones alike with a simple, if unexpected, visit. Sometimes even just a call.

Captain Bullshit lived to see people fully awake and engaged with the life around them. Whether it came at his hands or not made little difference. Sitting in the small park at Dash City’s edge, Captain Bullshit looked away from the duck pond, casting aside thoughts of mallards the size of trees laying egg-shaped presents throughout the city.

Instead, he raised his hands, and a dark brown snow began to fall. Cupping his palms, Captain Bullshit caught a mound of it and dug in. Whether they be crumbs or whole, he was a sucker for gingerbread cookies. And when they awoke the next morning, Dash City would have streets clogged with them. Enough for everyone to celebrate Christmas with a bit of Captain Bullshit’s favorite treat.

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# 9

Darting back to avoid another swing of those oversized paws, Tori let loose a torrent of fire onto her attacker. Flames wrapped around its entire stuffed body, yet the cursed thing refused to catch alight. That didn't mean it was immune to the damage, however, as huge chunks of it were burned away under Tori's assault. But when it counterattacked, sending her soaring upward, the embers upon it died out as well.

"This is total bullshit. You're made of stuffing and fabric. You should already be ashes." Floating high overhead, edging near the ceiling, Tori renewed her attack. Blasts of fire rained down on the giant bear, the majority of which were caught against its paws. Those deadly claws carved through her fire, reducing how much made it to the actual hands. Still, with her out of range, eventually she'd wear it down.

Unfortunately, it seemed the bear came to that same conclusion. With a mighty bellow, it swatted a nearby shelf so hard the entire thing went flying upward, contents included, all on a crash course for Tori. They passed through her harmlessly, of course, being physical objects moving through living flame. But it was still enough to distract her, and by the time Tori looked down once more, the bear was gone.

"Sure, might as well be able to sneak off and hide despite being an enormous bear. Why *wouldn't* that be one of your powers." Still muttering her distaste for magic, Tori scanned the area, penned in by the shelves which went all the way to the ceiling. Floating along, she had just enough time to wonder how in the hell elves the size of Twangle reached this high up before catching the sound of Ivan's voice calling for her.

Lowering herself back to the ground, constantly on watch for the stuffed bear, Tori returned to her human form. “Over here,” she yelled, and seconds later, Ivan sauntered into view at the end of her shelving aisle.

“Did something happen? The army of toys suddenly went still.”

“Oh, something happened, all right. I fought a stuffed bear the size of a real one, and it smacked me around in my fire-form.” Tori gestured to the scorch marks on the stone ground, noting that they appeared smaller than before. “I was able to drive it off, but Papa Bear was a lot harder than anything made of fabric should be against flames.”

Ivan’s mouth tugged downward in a short spasm. On most people, the minor expression would barely register, but to Tori, it stood out like a beacon. She knew how stoic her mentor tended to be. “Something I should be aware of?”

Motioning for her to follow, Ivan began walking down the aisles once more. “I fear that Twangle did not grasp the full breadth of the situation. Our evil spirit supposedly arrived possessing a single toy, yet you and I just saw a veritable army under its sway. That it was able to touch you is concerning, but nowhere near as worrying as the fact that it resisted your fire.”

Silent stares of motionless toys watched their walk, each utterly unmoving and still, not that it gave Tori much comfort. She could picture them leaping from the walls, cascading down from the ceiling-height shelves like a waterfall aiming to bury them alive.

“I am exceptional at burning shit,” Tori concurred.

Ivan shook his head. “Worryingly true, though not my point. This is a being of magic, and as such, should be vulnerable to fire. It is a primal force within magic circles, a source of life and death in different measures. Almost every magical being is affected by fire, with the exceptions being those who draw upon the element’s power themselves, those who have reached a level of power beyond the primal forces, and those with exceptionally potent magical defenses. Nothing about the spirit speaks to a connection with fire, which leaves us with the other two options.”

“Meaning this thing is either seriously warded, or so strong we’re screwed?”

“I strongly suspect the warding to be the answer.” Pausing, Ivan looked up and down a pair of aisles, then sniffed and turned left. “But that still leaves us the problem that either this spirit is much stronger than Twangle

realized, or it has grown in power since arriving at the North Pole. Of those, we should dearly hope Twangle was simply mistaken.”

Ivan stopped, a sharp grunt slipping from his lips. Tori looked over his shoulder, eyes going wide at what she saw. Scraps of stuffed animals littered the ground: a button-eye here, a floppy ear there, stuffing strewn out like scattered entrails. It was like someone had taken a weed whacker to the plushie section of a toy store, only the amount of debris seemed... small. Like there should have been a lot more remains for the number of destroyed toys she could see.

“That bastard is healing, isn’t it? Using the other toys as material to fix what I burned.”

“Its current form must be something special, if it would rather repair than jump ship and rebuild.” Ivan ran his hands through the remains, pausing suddenly. With a jerk, he tilted his head upward, to the shelves of intact toys. Approaching one, Ivan lifted a small wooden soldier off the shelf, turning it around before setting it down. “In other news, I believe I’ve figured out how it’s growing stronger.”

Tori twirled her finger in the air, a gesture for Ivan to continue, as she crept forward along the aisle, eyes peeled for any sudden swings of giant paws.

“Each gift made here contains a touch of magic, one that will fade once they are delivered. Our spirit evidently realized that by utilizing the materials of various toys, it could also feed upon their magic. I’d wager your giant bear was formed from hundreds of other stuffed animals, all stripped and repurposed.”

At the edge of the aisle, Tori checked both ends, nearly toppling back in surprise at what greeted her. “Hey, Ivan, do these warehouses have any sort of secret exits? Maybe the sort that go to hidden underground areas with weird, green-glowing lights?”

Seconds later, he was at her side, staring at the same strange sight. A large section of the stone ground had been lifted up, revealing a stairway leading down. Tori couldn’t make out any details, other than the emerald glow. She hoped Ivan would have more to offer, but he merely strode forward with a sigh.

“I’ve never seen that before, but there’s magic inside, so we have to assume it’s where our spirit has fled.”

“Shouldn’t you be in the loop on this stuff, being the Guardian of Christmas Magic and all?”

“Gods no,” Ivan replied. “This place might be cheery and fun, but magic this potent runs deep, and one of the first lessons I ever learned about magic still holds true: the more you know, the greater the danger you’re in.”

With that, he walked casually down the mysterious glowing stairs, leaving Tori to scramble after him.

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## IO

Despite what many might have expected after his betrayal, the former superhero known as Apollo was not buried in some maximum-security prison like Rookstone. While his powers did make Apollo a flight risk—quite literally, in his case—his record of service had also been brought into consideration.

Although his more recent actions had resulted in destruction and mayhem, there was no denying that Apollo had spent years of his life defending, protecting, and outright saving those in need. His attorney had called character witness after character witness, all offering tearful testimonies about the lives still ongoing thanks to Apollo's efforts. In the end, despite his own confession, he'd been assigned to a facility largely occupied by other capes who'd had slight falls from grace, rich crooks in for one sin or another, and celebrities whose careers still had hope for salvation.

It was utter bullshit, through and through. He was supposed to be punished, supposed to be atoning, and instead, there was a Christmas party going on in the theater with professional carolers and catered hot chocolate.

Looking out the southern window of his spacious cell, Apollo's eyes watched the night sky, hoping to see his former allies sailing among the stars. For all the mistakes that now seemed so obvious in hindsight, at least he hadn't messed this program up. There had certainly been opportunities; Professor Quantum was practically aquiver at the idea of gutting a Lodestar project. But Apollo had held firm, under the excuse that he didn't want to risk rocking the boat before officially ascending to a leadership role.

While the comfort was a small one, it felt earned, unlike the holiday spectacle entertaining everyone else. Or nearly everyone, as a guard walked down the hall, pausing outside Apollo's cell. It was Quiglen, a part human, part bull humanoid who'd been freed from a mad scientist's lair over a decade prior. With his muscular frame and visible horns, he was also one of the more obvious deterrents, just in case anyone did get thoughts of escaping.

"Got a visitor," the guard reported.

"I'm still not interested in talking to reporters. That goes for journalists, bloggers, or whatever else they call themselves now." Apollo kept his eyes on the sky, determined not to miss the glimpse of his old life.

"Do what you want, but if I had someone as pretty as Lady Shade calling on me, I sure wouldn't send her away." Quiglen waited by the cell door, tapping a partially hooved foot.

He should still refuse to go. That's what a truly repentant person should choose to do, wasn't it? Apollo was guilty, he knew that and wanted to face it head-on. Still, the most he'd been hoping for was a quick sight of his former friends from a distance. Knowing that one was close enough to hear her voice... meta or not, Apollo was only human.

"I suppose it wouldn't be very nice to keep her waiting, especially not on Christmas Eve."



"Okay, seriously, what the fuck is going on?" Beverly fought to keep her whisper contained, aware of the families nearby and her own cousins standing precariously close. She'd left them with Kristoph for a moment while dragging Johnny aside. There weren't many in a guild of villains she'd trust with small kids, but being with Kristoph made them about as safe as conceivably possible. "Are you guys planning to rob a mall Santa stand?"

"First off, we're the ones working this stand, so who exactly would we be stealing from?" Johnny was plainly tickled by her perplexment, his usual smarmy grin dialed up by several notches. "Secondly, just how small-time do you think we are?"

“Apparently small enough to knock out a bunch of mall workers and steal their outfits.” Even as she said it, though, Beverly realized that her words were wrong. Johnny’s costume fit perfectly, as did Kristoph’s, and Thuggernaut couldn’t steal clothes from anyone who wasn’t also a burly meta-human. These costumes were theirs, they had to be, which spoke to a more coordinated effort than she’d been expecting.

At the kiosk front, Kristoph waved his hands in a quick show of dexterity, producing several small candy canes in a sudden flash. Ansel and Sebastian both applauded politely, as did several others watching from the line.

“Knocked out some stooges? Please, check the quality of these curly shoes. We’re an officially licensed substitution team. When a mall Santa gets hurt, sick, or too drunk to make his shift, they call in teams like us to fill the gap. It’s our annual tradition, working as many shifts as we can the week before Christmas.”

“That only makes it all the weirder, Johnny. What the hell are you all up to?”

The door to Santa’s workshop thudded open, releasing a pair of happy kids racing off to their mother, who was waiting near the exit. Kristoph gently led Sebastian and Ansel into the workshop, neither one pausing for a moment, despite their earlier fears.

Stepping closer to her, the villain known as Johnny Three Dicks motioned to the huge line stretching back through the mall. “For all the things we can buy, steal, and build, do you know what most villains don’t have, Beverly? Happy childhoods. The kind of conditions required to gain power like ours and take the paths we do... it would be a lie to say that there are none, but it’s a rarity. I’m not one of the exceptions, nor is Thuggernaut.”

Mentally stepping back, Beverly examined the situation once more. Johnny and Thuggernaut were setting up Kristoph in a public place, one where countless people would parade past them every day. No, not just people... parents and caregivers. The ones who would be taking children to meet a mall Santa would most likely be those with a regular presence in their lives.

And each one had to meet with Kristoph at the kiosk. Kristoph’s power was immense and limited, as Beverly understood it. He had the ability to scan souls for signs of those that did willful damage to innocents, and when

he found someone who had committed such sins, the retribution was horrendous.

Understanding tumbled into place, and she looked at Johnny with a new sense of respect. “How do you keep him from acting as soon as he senses someone?”

“With a *lot* of convincing and earned trust. We had to explain that acting too soon tips off others. Better to let him meet as many as possible, then do the culling once we’ve wrapped for the day. After all, people are kind enough to leave their names and pay with credit cards. The Bytes have their addresses to us before I’ve even got my curly shoes off.”

“That’s the second time you’ve mentioned your shoes. Are you fishing for a compliment?” Beverly prodded.

Johnny shrugged, yet somehow in a way that caused the bells on his shoes to jingle. “I did the stitching myself.”

“Well, they do look nice. I’m just thrown a bit by all of... this.”

To that, Johnny Three Dicks chuckled darkly. “If you think this is something, be glad you aren’t around once the funny outfits come off. Having to wait only makes Kristoph meaner when he finally gets hold of them. The things I’ve seen on Christmas Eve often haunt me through the entire next year.”

The door to Santa’s workshop opened once more, freeing an excited Sebastian and Ansel as they came sprinting toward her. From inside, Thuggernaut offered a friendly wave, which Beverly returned. It was strange, realizing that the men she thought of fondly were planning to go on a murder spree later in the evening.

Stranger still, part of Beverly felt a twinge of guilt that she wouldn’t be around to help.

## II

Although the stairs were stone, everything else Tori could see appeared to be made of ice. Dark, thick ice under her feet, cold blue ice forming the walls, and a bright, twinkling ice overhead, gently illuminating the way. She shivered involuntarily, and felt some force within herself push back, exuding an aura of warmth. That cocoa really was incredible; a single mug had wiped out her biggest weakness. If she carried it around in a jug, she'd be borderline invincible.

One glance at Ivan removed all such delusions. She'd felt it for herself during a recent trip to Hallowville: cold vulnerability or not, there were metas who could take her down with minimal effort. Being invincible was a child's fantasy—for anyone not named Lodestar, at least.

"Any clues where we are?"

"Ice has layers. It would seem we're beneath the first, outermost shell of the North Pole. I doubt the spirit will be able to go deeper, but be sure that you don't either. The further down we dig, the older the secrets waiting to be uncovered."

Grunting in annoyance, Tori managed a nod of acknowledgment. "This is the kind of thing I hate about magic; it's total nonsense. How the hell does this place have ancient magical secrets when the meta-elements that make it possible got introduced less than a century ago?"

Ivan tapped one of the ice walls ever so softly, listening to the soft vibration that came from his soft strike. "How does Beverly have an old, inherited necklace with shape-shifting properties?"

"Same answer: magic bullshit."

“Maybe,” Ivan admitted. “It is a popular theory, the idea that magic interwove itself into our history upon its arrival. Such a thing upends our understanding of reality, but then, is that not the very nature of magic itself?”

“You don’t buy it?” Tori asked, picking up on the subtle shades of doubt in his seemingly stoic tone.

Finally turning from the ice wall, Ivan tilted his head, pondering for several long seconds. “I don’t. The array of recovered artifacts are too varied, aligning with historical records and beliefs with shocking consistency. Aside from that, the way magic flows through our world simply feels... natural, for lack of a better term. I hypothesize that magic was hiding, or more accurately, had been hidden until Professor Quantum’s experiment banged loose the seal.”

“Wouldn’t that beg the question of what hid it in the first place?”

“Only if I’m right,” Ivan reminded her.

Together, they started through the icy basement, walls opaque enough to block their view. Bits of stuffing and singed fur offered a path to follow, one that came a tad too easily for Tori’s liking. It made her sense of wariness tingle. Was the spirit leading them into a trap?

Her brief moment of concern evaporated seconds later, when she remembered that Ivan was here this time. That bear had been a bastard, no doubt about it, and Tori wouldn’t want to face it in tight quarters like these. But Ivan was the lid holding back a force of destruction that could level worlds; it would take a lot more than a magic grizzly to give him trouble.

Together, they wound through the twists and turns. At first, the walls were angular, just like one would expect from a constructed basement. But the longer they walked, the more Tori noticed a subtle curvature at each corner, slowly smoothing the walls into crisscrossing circular tunnels. The trail of debris grew more scattered, yet there was always enough to keep following.

With every scrap of fabric, Tori’s certainty that this was a trap grew stronger. “Does this trail strike you as conspicuous?”

“Certainly,” Ivan confirmed. “It’s attempting to lure us—or more specifically, me—inward. The seals barring it from the deeper layers can only be circumvented by certain means. As Guardian, my permission is one such avenue.”

“Why do I get the feeling it’s not planning a PowerPoint presentation on why you should let it past?”

“Mercifully, I doubt it’s that cruel. More likely, it plans to either try to kill me to steal the mantle for itself, or to use you as a hostage to force my permission.”

Ivan kept right on walking, but Tori stopped in place mid-stride. “Hang on, it’s going to what now?”

“Potentially use you as a bargaining chip. The spirit seems cunning, to lie in wait and build its power. The earlier attack was most likely a probe to determine your overall strength. It now knows you’re not a threat on par with me and may seek to exploit that perceived weakness.”

“Well shit, you sure seem broken up about the idea.”

Ivan finally stopped, turning around to meet Tori’s eyes properly. “It is not a worry I feel the need to waste time or thought entertaining. There was a reason I prefaced my statement as the two plans it would most likely *try* to attempt. This spirit has a limited sense of scale to work with, and being weaker than Fornax does not mean that you aren’t a threat. It will likely have to learn that the hard way, though.”

Fighting the urge to blush at the unexpected show of faith in her, Tori tucked her head and hurried to catch up with Ivan. Together, they continued moving through the tunnels, winding through a far greater space than the warehouses could possibly occupy, before at last coming to a slope leading up.

Climbing up for a brief spell, Tori found herself at the mouth of a massive ice cavern, one that seemed to stretch on for miles. And filling every inch she could see was a motley assortment of shapes. Weathered plastic figurines, dented tin soldiers, dolls with cracks running along their porcelain faces.

Toys. An endless army of toys exponentially bigger than anything they’d seen aboveground. And standing at the forefront, once more whole and stitched together from an array of other stuffed sources, waited the enormous bear.

Tentatively, Tori tried to creep back out, but the bear’s roar echoed through the cavern, reverberating down to her very bones. As one, the army surged forward, thundering toward her and Ivan’s position. No doubt about it, they’d definitely been spotted, and the swarm of toys was coming to pick them clean.

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## I2

Music came from all directions. Some of it appropriate to the season, some utterly unrelated, and a few chords sounded like chaos incarnate. Across the island, dozens of private celebrations were being held, though none of them compared to the main party occurring at the central facility.

Most of them were gathered outside, where countless non-sentient robots toured around offering various food and drinks. A hulking man who appeared to be half hammerhead shark scooped up a glass of eggnog and a handful of canapés from a passing tray, throwing them all down his gullet in seconds. Had the many people of the seas tormented by the villain called Depthcharge seen such a sight... well, they likely still would have run screaming.

All around them, Lance and Warren could see villains of incredible power and renown enjoying the festive atmosphere. Thick, silly sweaters were clad around each of the Bytes, the three technology-talented metas who handled the majority of the guild's hacking.

An entity that looked like a floating squid made of glass had somehow fashioned a red Santa hat to its mantle, though the bottom layer of the fluffy white trim was starting to erode. Nearby, an outdoor screen and stereo were being setup for some clip show that was apparently a standing tradition. Gork and Morgana, two of the guild's Councilors, were gathered around a microphone atop an outdoor stage, committing perhaps one of their careers' greatest crimes against the poor song being butchered. It was a small mercy that in all the noise and chaos of the island, their voices didn't travel far.

Warren himself was slowly sipping on a glass of eggnog, while Lance had already downed his fifth mixed drink of the night. The two were quite

different, even at a glimpse. While Lance's size and build framed him as a clear athlete, Warren's slender frame visibly reflected his more academic nature. Then, there were their countenances, with Lance's perpetually friendly smile and friendly nature contrasted against Warren's pinched expression, forming what looked like a perpetual scowl.

Neither had expected a deep friendship to take root, but facing danger together time after time had formed a bond of trust, which had steadily deepened to genuine enjoyment. Perched together in lounging chairs, watching the guild cut loose, Lance was glad he had someone to share these strange sights with.

"And you wanted to go home for Christmas Eve," Warren reminded him.

"This is something all right, but they don't have PeePaw's world famous cobbler," Lance countered. "If there's not plenty left tomorrow, my family is waking up to a huge case of bed bugs." Given his ability to summon and control insects of all types, including some meta-species, that threat was far from idle, even if he did have a silly smile in place while it was delivered.

From the ocean to their left, a tremendous splash rose up as a woman at least forty feet tall leapt from the side of their volcano lair, doing a cannonball as she landed. Biglia didn't always take up so much space, but tonight was clearly about letting their hair down. The wave rising toward the island was cut off by a round of laser fire from automated defenses, boiling the water to nothing before it could make landfall.

"You keep talking about that cobbler. By this point, it would have to heal the lame and raise the dead to live up to your descriptions." Warren punctuated the point with a big gulp of his eggnog, coughing slightly on the oversized sip.

"Well, why don't you come along and find out for yourself then? Tunnel Vision can send two as easy as one, and I already booked the portal," Lance offered. He could feel Warren's eyes combing over him as the words left, hunting for... something.

After several awkward seconds, Warren managed a response. "Are you sure? You really want to bring any of this"—he motioned to the raucous celebration unfolding before them, on an island lair of a villain's guild—"home to your family?"

To that, Lance laughed and shook his head. "Not a bit. I'm not inviting the guild, just a friend who could use some good cobbler. Besides, no one

should be alone on Christmas.”

Wordlessly, Warren nodded, shifting in his seat slightly so his eyes weren't quite visible. Lance made no comment on the movement, nor the slight redness in Warren's eyes when he looked back.



The red sleigh was soaring over San Francisco when a blazing light dropped out of the sky next to it. Within that burning aura was a woman, one who carried herself with a gentle smile despite the unfathomable power she wielded. Santa's back shivered at the sight of her; there were few entities he truly feared, but she was among them. With her every breath, the world shuddered, eagerly waiting for her will to manifest.

In a blink, she'd closed the distance, despite the magical, time-warping effect shrouding him. This was no negation of the power, one that allowed him to visit so many houses in a single night, it was far worse. She was simply that much faster, magic or no.

“Good evening!” Her smile touched her voice, the cheerful greeting a lure to draw him in. She even added a wave. “Fancy running into you here. Small world, huh?”

“Begone!” Santa commanded, raising a fist wrapped in a worn, leather glove. “Quit your heresy and defiance of the ancient lesson.”

The smile didn't waver, but she shook her head and released an audible sigh. “One of these years, you and I are going to have a sit-down and talk this out. I refuse to believe you don't understand what we're doing, even if it runs counter to your own methods.”

“You rebuke the very foundation of this holiday!” Santa's voice was rising, and he looked around for something loose in the sled that might make a projectile. When he glanced up again, she was inches from his face, effortlessly matching the sleigh's pace.

“Maybe I do,” she agreed at last. “But some foundations need to be broken.”

Then she was gone, fast as she'd arrived, leaving Santa in peace. He hurried to shake off the encounter; there was still a tremendous amount of work to be done. The typically jolly man in red had no more thought to spare over that blasphemous entity who called herself Lodestar.

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# 13

Tori was speaking even as the fireball formed between her hands. “All due respect to whatever debts you owe as the Holiday Handler or whatever, but I’m not fucking dying to a bunch of toys.”

“Nor would I expect you to.” Despite the turn of events, Ivan was unbothered, watching calmly as the wave of plastic and felt stormed toward them. “Potent as this spirit might be, its intelligence is still rudimentary. Our fight upstairs seems to have given it a serious misconception.”

As the toys drew closer, Tori could make out more details. The chipped porcelain faces, uneven wheels on the cars, stuffed rabbits with ears where the arms should go—that last one was particularly unnerving, though Tori couldn’t put her finger on why.

“It clearly believes we won’t destroy any toys other than its main body. But these are plainly from the ‘rework’ pile, pilfered from under the elves’ noses. Which means...”

Ivan let the words trail off as he suddenly bounded forward, slapping a hand into a toy octopus holding a knife in each tentacle. It exploded into debris, but the wave of destruction traveled outward, obliterating every object within twenty feet. In an instant, the army had a hole in its forces, though more poured through to fill it.

“There are no children awaiting these, ready to be disappointed by Christmas. I’m only limited by how much force I think this structure’s magic can endure.” In the strange light of the icy cavern, it wasn’t quite easy to see, but Tori felt almost entirely certain that Ivan was smiling.

If the spirit *had* possessed a lick of intellect, that sight would have sent it screaming into the night. Instead, it bellowed a mighty roar, and the army

of toys only surged forward faster.

Having built up a potent blast, Tori turned the flames loose, a focused inferno blazing through countless tiny terrors. The plastic toys rushed forward, melting as they moved, but shielding their stuffed battalions from instant incineration. By the time Tori cut off her flames, there were dozens of plastic puddles staining the ice before her.

Ivan had been busy as well, destroying chunks of the battlefield one punch at a time. It was awe-inspiring, to see the way he effortlessly wiped away opponents, especially considering this was barely a fraction of what he *could* be doing. If he weren't worried about bringing down the whole cavern, and perhaps even the Christmas town residing overhead, Ivan would have already cleaned house.

Not that his current pace was anything to be ashamed of, as he kicked a tiny tank into shrapnel, each piece tearing through adjacent toys and cutting them to pieces. Tori was having to work a little harder as the army drew in closer, surrounding her on all fronts. Streams of fire kept them at bay, but the tide truly seemed to be endless. Rather than risk being overwhelmed, Tori took to the air once more, shifting into her fire-form.

No sooner had she touched the sky than another roar rang out, accompanied by the sounds of movement. The big bear had apparently been expecting this, its huge heft hurtling toward her. In her mind's eye, she could already see it bounding up, managing to strike her back toward the ground, where a seething mass of plastic limbs would be waiting to pull her apart. The small enemies should have been helpless against her insubstantial shape, but with magic in play, nothing was certain.

Before she could concoct a counterplan, the bear leapt. Its arm span was wide enough to catch Tori if she dodged left or right, and going down would put her directly in its landing path. Up was an option; however, it wouldn't carry her fully out of swiping range. At least, not currently.

In a blast of movement, Tori shot upward toward the ceiling, even as her body started to shift. The humanoid form pulled in tight, until she was nothing more than a blazing sphere roughly a foot across. In this form, there was no reason she *had* to be shaped like herself, save that it felt natural. But a few moments of discomfort were an excellent trade to avoid being slapped out of the air.

Though its claws came near enough for her to feel their force as they cut through the air, Tori managed to avoid the bear's strike, her opponent

landing with an angry roar. It was already turning for another go, but sounds from behind drew its attention instead. The bear looked to find Ivan standing nearby, having closed the gap while it was distracted by Tori. Although it attempted to scurry back, Ivan's fist was already drawn. The bear never stood a chance.

One punch sent it screaming through the air, slamming into the back wall with an explosion of ice and stuffing. Still, it tried to rise, unsteady limbs managing to wobble in place. Chunks of its fur fell away in patches, like they'd been seared off, and stuffing fell freely from its sides.

Tori unbound herself, stretching out to normal proportions. The army still raged below her, but with their main spirit on the verge of collapsing, she didn't expect them to be much trouble. In fact, they'd already started tottering over, she realized. Starting from one side of the cavern, they were toppling like dominoes, the magic animating each one cut away like a thin string.

As Tori tracked the wave of death, she realized something else. Her gaze was perfectly matching the bear's; wherever it looked, toys fell over lifeless. "Ivan! I think it's up to something."

"And I was starting to worry we'd wasted a trip." He stood, unbothered, as the army toppled at his feet. Ivan only had eyes for his night's opponent, which was still refusing to fall. Suddenly, the toys started to move once more, though not with any sort of agency.

Instead, it was as if a force was dragging them along the ground, pulling them like multicolored rivers toward a single point: the bear. Plastic, metal, felt, and more, all melded together as the toys combined, a twisted amalgamation already rising from their nearly beaten foe.

"Shouldn't you put a stop to that?" Tori called, still floating out of easy reach.

"Spirits can spread their power, and it makes wiping them out tricky if they're smart with it. Better to let it put every egg in a single basket." An undeniable grin crept along Ivan's face, hidden from the world by layers of magical ice overhead.

"Then we can smash them all with one blow."

Cold air rushed past Tachyonic's face as he ran through the night. The world felt silent and still when moving at the speeds he could. People passed in slow motion, the sound waves of life muffled by the hum of his own power crackling. There was a peace in the world that existed for super-speeders, one he could never quite explain to the others.

Occasionally, he would catch sight of another form moving at "normal" speeds, usually through the sky. He'd never seen so many super-speed metas gathered together in one place before that evening. While much of the AHC pitched in somehow, those who could fly or move fast occupied special roles in the night's proceedings.

A flash of light tore through the sky overhead, and Tachyonic suppressed a shudder. Even going this fast, Lodestar was still no more than a blur. Part of him wondered how much the rest of them were *really* needed for all this, with her on the task. It certainly should have been impossible, but then, so should driving off an enormous, asteroid-sized creature that devoured sunlight. Glad as he was to have her on their side, there was something inherently terrifying about knowing any one person had *that* much power.

At least she found good uses for it, such as tonight's event. Following the Quantum Guidance System built into his suit's mask, Tachyonic veered off into a rundown apartment building, running into and out of three units before the residents had a chance to notice, leaving lighter than he'd arrived.

Back on the street, Tachyonic's mind turned to the years of Christmas past. Were they still on Vomisa, there would be the annual celebration.



While Professor Quantum had no interest in holidays, he did recognize that those working for him enjoyed them and considered the trade-off in productivity worthwhile for overall morale and efficiency. All of which led to a pretty solid party every winter season.

Bands would play, waiters with silver trays would serve fancy canapés, and dignified guests would ooh-and-aah over whatever trinkets Professor Quantum opted to trot out. The true science stayed buried in the island's vaults, hidden even to the vast majority of its residents. But no one complained, because they weren't there for science in the first place. People turned up for the celebration; work was just a handy excuse.

If they were lucky, Ike would steal a few glasses of champagne for the quartet to share. Inwardly, Tachyonic winced, reminding himself that they were now a trio. That thought burned something fierce, trying to bring tears to his eyes, but Tachyonic had gotten too much practice fighting them back in the months since Ike passed. He wouldn't give in now, especially when there was work to be done.

Despite himself, Tachyonic smiled. Ike would have loved tonight's endeavor. In a way, it was done for people just like him. Had he been there, Tachyonic imagined he'd have been teleporting from roof to roof, filling the comms with inane chatter all the while.

Instead, Tachyonic ran through his world of stillness, no longer quite as comforted by the silence.



“You can’t be serious.” Ren’s voice, once garbled by his altered tongue, came out crisp and clear as he expertly enunciated the words, months of hard work showing themselves. It was rather unfortunate that he’d made the effort, because in that moment, his talking trouble would have been a perfect excuse.

Lucy shook her head, those oversized, earnest eyes looking like they peered right into his very soul. While she might be a capable superhero when fighting as Hat Trick, there was something about her mundane identity that made it hard not to want to take care of her. Even saying no to something so ridiculous filled Ren with twinges of guilt, and the eyes only made it worse.

“Oh, come on. If *I’m* going to do it, you can, too.” Irene didn’t have Lucy’s entrancing eyes. In fact, she was more comfortable with a glare than anything else. “Donald’s out helping with the night project, but we already did our lifting shifts and are dismissed for the night. You really want to sit around here by yourself?”

In truth, what Ren wanted was to be back home for a normal holiday. After a storm of meta-elements and energies left Ren as a hybrid of various animal genetics, his life had gone considerably offtrack. Gone was football, the scholarships, even the very college they’d been needed for. Far worse, Ren had lost his own body. The face he’d seen in the mirror every day was gone, and while the Alliance of Heroic Champions had mercifully provided him with an enchanted illusion device to appear human, he still didn’t look like himself. His new frame simply couldn’t fit those dimensions.

The change had been difficult, but gaining new powers and purpose had helped Ren with the transition. His family didn’t have those comforts; all they saw when they looked at him was what had been lost. Every time he came around, somebody broke down in tears, and he just couldn’t handle that again. Not for now.

With a grunt, Ren reached out and accepted the scarf from Lucy, matching the ones she and Irene were both already wearing. It was a strange fit, wrapping around the scales and fur that coated his body, but she’d gotten him an extra-long one with plenty of material to wrap.

Lucy clapped at the sight, and Irene flashed a rare smile. “Knew you’d come around.”

“We’re going to have so much fun,” Lucy declared. “My friends and I used to do this all the time, and now, we get to do it as superheroes! Imagine people’s faces when they see Medley joining in.”

That image was more or less the exact one Ren had been trying to avoid. Going out in their AHC identities meant that he’d be seen as a monster. One on the side of good, but a monster all the same. Still, if he ever hoped to win more hearts, it would start with activities exactly like this one. There was a chance that Lucy had even organized it with him in mind, not that she’d ever admit it.

Searching his brain one last time for a viable excuse, Ren found nothing, and finally conceded defeat.

“I’ve never been caroling before,” Ren admitted. “What songs do I need to know?”

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When the last of the smaller toys was finally gone, only a hulking beast remained. While its original incarnation had been akin to a grizzly, the bear's new form was roughly the size of a house, one with a second story and at least four bedrooms. Three heads roared from its shoulders, six arms with claws swung heavily through the air, and four sturdy legs carried it forward. If some lunatic scientists with a grudge had dedicated themselves to creating an ursine nightmare, Tori wasn't sure they could have done a better job.

The roar echoed through the cavern with ferocious force; had Tori been in physical form, her eardrums would likely have burst. Ivan, of course, was as unbothered by the noise as he was the monstrosity charging toward him. He walked steadily forward in his usual gait, like he was traipsing down the halls of his office to make photocopies.

A massive paw flew through the air, slamming down onto Ivan so hard it sent a shockwave across the floor. There wasn't so much as a groan or a creak from the cavern, let alone a crack in the ice. The way deeper was barred in a way that force couldn't overwhelm. At least, not force of that level.

With a casual backhand, Ivan blasted the paw, sending the bear reeling back in the process. It roared in fury, this time slashing down with its claws. They scraped along the ice, drawing sparks somehow, because magic did whatever it wanted, apparently. Too bad for the bear, Ivan was technically magic too.

Each claw shattered on impact, the pieces whirling through the air, most hitting the ground and skittering into the walls. Overhead, however, Tori

noticed that several shards lodged into the ice. The way down was protected, but she wasn't sure just how much the top layer would be able to withstand.

No wonder Ivan hadn't simply blown it away with a single punch. She'd watched the way those earlier toys exploded; if the bear detonated, it could easily bring down whatever was above them, and probably a good chunk of anything nearby.

The next roar rippled through the air like physical force. She could practically hear the rage over its broken claws. Two of the heads thrust down, jaws snapping, intent on devouring Ivan even as he remained patiently standing.

Part of Tori felt a tug of obligation to help, but she smothered that impulse immediately. The world of meta-humans was not a place of fair fights and balanced equations. Battling against Alfred Settler had driven home that point in a way no amount of words ever could. She understood that there were foes she simply couldn't stand against, and trying would only turn her into needless collateral damage.

Of course, that was only for now. Tori had ambitions far beyond limits like these. One day, she intended to build a meta-suit that could stand toe-to-toe with not just foes like the bear, but even Ivan himself. As his apprentice, reaching her teacher's same heights was the bare minimum to strive for.

Watching the enormous jaws break on Ivan's arm, it sank in once again just how far away that dream truly was. Fangs the size of traffic cones ground into powder against the semi-translucent aura surrounding Ivan's body; apparently, he'd conjured a ward. When the first of the bear's mouths pulled back, it was with a mouthful of shattered and largely-useless teeth.

The second head tried to retreat, but it had made the mistake of entering Ivan's reach. His hand snapped out, grabbing it by the jaw and twisting. A yelp of pain tore forth, along with the very jaw Ivan was holding. Rather than blood, liquid plastic ran from the wound, slowly sealing over. Retreating, the bear tried to put distance between itself and Ivan.

"Let this be a lesson on the limitations of size," Ivan called to Tori. "While there is an advantage of strength, leverage, and mass, most capable opponents have ways to mitigate those factors. And once they're gone, all you've really done is make yourself a much larger target."

In a swift bound, Ivan crossed the meager distance his enemy had gained, grabbing one of the four legs and yanking hard. The bear was jerked off-balance and crashed hard onto the ice below. Keeping his grip, Ivan twisted his hand once more, and just like that, there were only three functional legs. The fourth hump limply, dragging down any attempt at escape.

With fleeing failed, the bear switched back to offense, arms slamming into Ivan with everything it could manage. None of the hits were effective, usually hurting the bear instead, but it continued without a moment's break, the barrage unending. Yet as it slammed paw after paw onto Ivan, Tori couldn't help but notice the way it was shifting its legs, like it was reorienting.

As they bunched up, understanding flooded through her, and Tori blasted herself upward toward the icy roof. Halting a dozen feet below, she hurriedly tried to gather heat as fast as possible, even while shouting to Ivan. "The ceiling isn't protected! It's going to try and smash through."

Whether spurred by her words or simply ready to act, the bear chose that moment to leap upward. Ivan instantly snared one of its legs, and Tori almost released her building heat, but the pessimist in her demanded she keep going. That wisdom was unfortunately proven sound as she watched the leg Ivan was holding simply disconnect with an audible *pop*.

The bear was still hurtling upward, leaving its leg behind, one good mouth open and roaring as it raced toward Tori. She needed to move; *of course*, she needed to move. Those enormous jaws would probably chew through her in any form, just like the paw had hit her. This beast was well out of her current league, and it was time to retreat.

Instead, Tori blasted every bit of fire she could conjure directly down its open throat. The reaction was instantaneous, fur around its mouth catching fire, its flesh melting like... well, plastic. Whatever fireproofing magics had guarded its older form, they weren't potent enough to protect something this big. It hurriedly slapped at its own face, trying to extinguish the flames. Tori used the distraction to blast herself between its limbs as the bear zipped past.

Rather than bash into the ceiling with its fangs and broken claws, the bear hit ribs first, causing a few small cracks, but no major damage. On the way down, however, it was not quite so distracted as before. When Tori tried to slip its reach once again, it threw a headbutt at her, which she

dodged. Unfortunately, that put her directly in line with its broken leg, which the bear still swung down like a limp club.

Weakened strike or not, the blow still hit Tori dead-on, giving not one iota of concern for her semi-intangible nature. Like a falling comet, Tori was sent hurtling toward the ice below.

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## 16

Stockings were hung by the chimney with care, the dying embers of a roaring fire flickering below. Four of them, each labeled with an embroidered name. Juan, Rick and Beth's stepfather, had made each one for their first Christmas together. It had been a strained, uncomfortable event, back when they were a newly changed family still finding its footing.

A muted television set showed scenes of *Justice Hound Saves Christmas*, but the room's lone occupant wasn't paying attention. Rick Gerhardt couldn't sleep. That was not an unusual occurrence, even before learning the truth about his father. Ever since discovering who Ivan really was, watching with the rest of the world as his father wiped out untold lives and then tortured the last survivor, the sleepless nights had been growing ever more frequent.

They didn't start out sleepless. Rick would drift off as normal, falling into some innocuous dream... then, the nightmares would come. Most often, he saw his father killing shapeless beings, cackling with mad laughter all the while. Worse was when the enemies became real, taking the form of Wrexwren, or the fishlike creatures Rick still had only scattered memories of. Another army his father had obliterated.

Even still, those were a pleasant stroll through a meadow compared to the ones where Ivan turned those murderous eyes on his own family. Images of coming home to find only wreckage and Fornax. Visceral as those nightmares were, they also fell apart the fastest. Part of Rick simply couldn't accept the idea of his father hurting him or Beth.

Sounds from the staircase pulled Rick's attention, and he spotted Beth lingering at the stairs. "If you wait up for Santa, he'll skip the house."



“You’re thirteen years old. I know Mom had the Santa talk with you already,” Rick chided.

“Two weeks ago, Captain Bull-You-Know-What made mermaids burst from the sea and free the exhibits from a Florida aquarium. Last month, a moth made of candy tried to eat a New York skyscraper. Is Santa really any crazier than all that?”

She padded down the stairs and plopped down in a faded green lounge. “Are you worried about going to Dad’s tomorrow?”

“Why would I—”

“Things have been weird between you two for months,” Beth interrupted. “When we go over, you spend a lot more time out of the house.”

“I’m allowed to have friends.”

“But since when have you been capable?” Beth teased. “For real though, I know your friends. They’re not the type to hang out all day, unless it’s somewhere online.”

Much as Rick wanted to tell her, he held his tongue. Aside from his deal with Ivan, he just couldn’t do that to his little sister. Finding out who their father really was, the blood that ran in their own veins... Rick still wasn’t sure if he’d rather have gone on in happy ignorance. But he did know he wasn’t taking that joy from Beth, and especially not on Christmas Eve.

“I’m not worried about going to Dad’s,” Rick lied. “Maybe I was trying to catch a peek at Santa, after all.”

“Uh huh. Well then, why don’t we wait together? Sitting alone in the dark isn’t very Christmasy.” Reaching over to the coffee table, Beth unmuted the television, just as the movie flashed away to a commercial.



Pouring himself a glass of vitamin-enriched water, Professor Quantum took a break from his current project, savoring the quiet. Much as he disliked the work required of him for the yearly event, and had fought diligently against its initial inception, he could admit to enjoying the solitude it offered.

With virtually every member of their organization active on the same day, there were no chatting chums wandering the halls, polluting the peace with their ceaseless prattle. Crimes were already minimal on this date, and

with so many forces of the AHC out and active, culprits would be swiftly apprehended.

It *still* galled him to no end that this operation was conducted in secret. The amount of logistical hurdles they had to climb, the utterly ludicrous amount of goodwill left unclaimed... it boggled the mind. That they purchased and used AHC-produced goods was a mild concession that admittedly did help make it all easier to swallow. Had this date come prior to the Wrexwren invasion, Professor Quantum might very well have demanded that they bring it to light, an easy route back into the public's good graces.

After Lodestar sent a sun-eating monster running into the cosmos, though... people had gotten a very tangible reminder of why they trusted the Alliance of Heroic Champions to start with. Because, when chaos came calling, they were there to hold the line. There was still tremendous ground to be regained, but it wasn't worth pushing tonight's event into the public eye. Lodestar could be particular about that sort of thing, and he needn't risk her working against him.

Walking over to his computer monitor, Professor Quantum sent an automated holiday message to his staff back on Vomisa. Even there, he'd had to capitulate to the community's needs and allow festivities. Employing the best and brightest demanded that the job be alluring, and things like refusing people time off for holidays had cost him several promising scientists through the early years. In the end, what mattered most was their efficiency, and his data demonstrated that happy workers performed at higher levels.

Polishing off his water, Professor Quantum set aside his distractions and returned to the task at hand. Sitting on his table, surrounded by all manner of scientific instruments, was a snow globe of a small country cabin. Within the glass, tiny clouds sent an endless storm of flurries onto the scene below. Wind swirled occasionally, causing the flakes to dance in an entrancing pattern.

The globe was magical, one of countless trinkets Professor Quantum had purchased through the years. Though he had no hope that *this* would be the one to help him crack open the conundrum that was magic, it would offer more pieces of precious data. Sooner or later, he would find the tipping point, the place of understanding where this seemingly nonsensical

force could finally be grasped. His science would conquer all challenges, even its own apparent antithesis.

And if that time happened to come tonight, well, what a lovely Christmas the world would be in for.

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Tori barely had time to brace for the chilly impact. Slamming into enchanted ice, fire-form or not, was going to sting. But the freezing surface never reached her. Instead, Tori found herself gripped in a pair of strong arms. Despite her semi-intangible state and ridiculous speed, he'd caught her with ease, spinning in place to burn off her excess momentum.

When they came to a halt, Tori looked up and realized that it wasn't quite Ivan who'd caught her after all, not entirely. His own eyes were gone; in their place, the black voids lit only by burning red runes. Those were the eyes that came out when Ivan got serious.

Fornax's eyes.

"That's enough of that." Slowly releasing his grip, Ivan allowed Tori to float away, the entirety of his attention on the still smoldering bear that was slapping out its face, extinguishing the flames. Every step he took seemed to reverberate through the enormous cavern, like the steady ticking of a final clock.

Gathering its strength, the bear moved to leap once more, and suddenly, the distance between them was simply gone. The short-ranged teleportation was one of Ivan's favorite moves in combat, handy for closing the distance, disorienting an opponent, or avoiding a deadly blow. In this case, he appeared at the bear's side and grabbed it by the torso, hands clutching at its fractured ribs.

"I said *enough*." With a twist of his body, Ivan slammed the bear down onto the cavern's nigh-unbreakable floor. Its roar was a strangle of rage and pain as Ivan kept his hand clutched tight, pinning his enemy in place.

“Much as I enjoy a bit of Christmas combat, you seem to have forgotten who your opponent is. Allow me to help you remember.”

Ivan’s hand pulsed as he poured some manner of raw magic into the captured beast. Instantly, its screams took on a new cadence. The prior roars had come from anger and hurt; this bubbled up from fear. The bear was bellowing in desperate terror as its flesh was violently unmade.

More than that, Tori could see a glowing figure within the toy, one that was coming apart just as fast as the plastic and stuffing around it. The howls rose, growing in fervor and volume, no longer that of a simple animal.

“My apprentice has a poor habit of forgetting that some degree of invulnerability does not protect against every threat. It seems you, too, suffer from such a failing. As you were so polite as to offer her instruction this evening, I can’t help but return the kindness.” Ivan’s wicked grin undercut the polite words, those red runes in his eyes gleaming bright. “Let me show you what it is to hurt.”

Another pulse rippled from his hand, a wave of destruction that unmade nearly half the creature in a single moment. The remains fell to the ground, no longer cohesive enough to stand. Wisps of white energy rose up and started flowing together, causing the toy-flesh to deteriorate even faster.

Over it all, Ivan stood, glaring down in judgment. “This was where I’d have left things. But you overreached, and I’m not one to teach the same lesson twice.” Dashing forward, Ivan drove his hands into the largest blob of energy, another wave of destruction already pouring forth. When it detonated, nothing but the ice was spared.

From her vantage point across the cavern, Tori shivered for reasons that had nothing to do with the cold. Ivan was one of the most reliable people in her life, and had proven more than once that he cared about her well-being. Yet he was also one of the most deadly, dangerous beings she’d ever encountered. Most of the time, he did his wicked deeds with a sort of resignation to the necessity. When he started smiling, enjoying himself, her mind couldn’t help flickering back to the day he’d lost himself entirely.

Thankfully, Ivan was still well in control, as he calmly examined the area, searching for any telltale wisps of light slinking off to recover. When he was fully satisfied that the threat had been purged, Ivan walked over to check on her.

Tori returned to human form, feeling a bit battered, yet overall, no worse for the wear. She didn’t imagine fighting as living fire in a cavern of

ice would usually go so well, but the cocoa really did push back the cold. Magic was still bullshit, that didn't mean it couldn't be bullshit in her favor though.

"You all right?"

"Fit and fine, though I'm probably never going to look at teddy bears the same way again." Tori hauled herself to her feet, relieved to see Ivan's normal eyes were once more looking down at her. "Anything else we need to do here?"

Ivan shook his head, even as he started walking toward the cavern's exit. "The elves handle the cleanup, and I didn't leave much for them, anyway."

The pair walked back through the icy hallways, Tori only occasionally staring at the floor, wondering what sorts of wonders and horrors lurked below. After climbing the stairs back into the warehouse and navigating their way to the exit, they discovered a small figure waiting for them.

"The True North thanks its Guardian, and his aide." To Tori's surprise, Twangle bowed to them, dipping so low his face nearly brushed the snowy ground. From behind his back, a pair of carefully wrapped presents appeared, one being handed to each of them.

Ivan's looked to be roughly the size of a book, whereas Tori's was lumpy and misshapen. Her mentor very carefully tucked his under an arm before addressing Twangle. "My duty is done. The magic is preserved."

"The Guardian has served well," Twangle agreed.

A sudden wind passed over them, soft and severe at the same time. Neither Ivan nor Twangle looked surprised, so she chalked it up to more magic and put the matter out of mind. When the wind finished, Twangle stepped into the warehouse, a team of more elves suddenly appearing from behind him. As for she and Ivan, they began walking back into the snowy wilds.

After they were some distance away, Ivan produced his bell and rang it once more. Out of nothingness, a doorway appeared, one leading back to his condo. It was an especially lovely sight after the night they'd had, and Tori was more than happy to walk through and plop down on his couch.

Ivan followed only a few steps behind, the portal closing behind him as he gently set his present under the tree. "I'd recommend stowing that gift safely until morning. Magic has balance, and we served Christmas well tonight. The reward should be valuable—to us, if no one else."

Much as Tori wanted to do nothing more than lounge, she wasn't so exhausted as to ignore Ivan's advice, especially when it came to anything mystical. With a grunt of annoyance, she rose once more, bringing her own present to set under the twinkling tree.

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When Christmas morning came, there was no joy in the heart of Jericho Gibson. He already knew there would be no presents waiting for him. If anything, he imagined his parents were glad for the excuse. Ever since Mom lost her job, they'd been struggling; more than once, he'd heard snatches of worried conversation about how they'd afford a holiday when barely making ends meet.

Could they really have been that shocked when he was caught stealing? Like they hadn't noticed his little sister Denise suddenly wearing shoes without holes and new dresses that actually fit? But once he was caught, it was all limitations this and punishment that. No Christmas, no traditions like putting cookies out for Santa—to him, it would be a regular day. Honestly, Jericho didn't care about the presents, or even being grounded on Christmas. What bothered him most was that he'd been caught trying to grab a jacket Denise really needed.

Opening his eyes to greet the day, Jericho nearly tumbled out of his bed when he saw the present sitting at its edge. Wrapped in a brilliant blue with white ribbon, it even had a card with his name written. Had his parents changed their minds after all?

Tearing in without hesitation as only a child could, he found himself staring at a dense mound of tissue paper with a note resting on top. Had Santa left him a message? With great care, he lifted the note and started to read.

*“Now, obviously, stealing is wrong, but I happen to have a soft spot for over-protective big brothers. Still, you need to think about what's best for you both in the long term. If you keep going down this path, will you be able*



*to watch over her from juvenile detention, or one day, prison? On the back of these pages are the numbers of some local services that I happen to know have just gotten sizable donations to their funding. Whether you call or not is up to you. All I can do is offer. No matter what you choose, though, I hope you have a wonderful holiday.*

*P.S. Officially speaking, there is a very strict one-present-per-child rule on this. However, it seems that somehow your sister's gift got added to your box, as well. Please be a dear and pass it along."*

Jericho's hands were tearing through the paper, until he found himself looking at a replica of Carbonizer's famous flying car, ordinarily a gift that would have stopped him in his tracks. Yet he kept going, digging deeper, until his hands closed around smooth fabric. He pulled, yanking the item fully free.

From within the box came a thick, heavy winter jacket exactly Denise's size. Golden lines crossed the dark exterior dotted with stars, creating an intricate, downright beautiful pattern. On the front, those lines twisted together to form a golden "L." He'd seen this kind of merchandise in the windows of high-end shops they were always hurried past; it was a line of fashion designed after the AHC's most famous heroes. Denise was going to absolutely love it.

Sitting on his bed, the first rays of light streaming through his window, Jericho found his eyes filling despite his best efforts to tamp them down. He would wait until they stopped to bring Denise her present. She didn't need to see him crying on Christmas.



Resting against a water tower on the roof of a building in some town north of Des Moines, Donald wolfed down a breakfast sandwich and a cup of lukewarm coffee. He'd spent the night as Cyber Geek, flying around dropping off parcels, making noise on roofs, and basically biting the shit out of Santa's style. The activities were weird enough, but the destinations... he'd reached a hypothesis early in the night, one that had only proven truer the longer he worked.

"They make some good grub around here." Lodestar landed a few feet away from him, a greasy brown bag tightly in her grip. From within, she

produced a biscuit laden with cheese, egg, and bacon, which lasted all of three bites before she went in for another. “So, how was your first Christmas Eve with the Alliance of Heroic Champions?”

“It was good,” Donald replied stiffly, all too aware of just who was trying to make casual chit-chat with him. “I got a lot of flight training in, worked with people I hadn’t met yet; overall, I had a fun time.”

Another sandwich was gone before Lodestar responded. “Glad to hear it. And I’m guessing you’re also a little confused, right?”

Shifting awkwardly in his seat on the roof’s edge, Donald tried to think of how to politely phrase his next words. “I’m fairly sure I’ve figured it out. The houses weren’t a tipoff, but after the third juvenile detention center, I had enough clues to make a guess. What I don’t quite get is why the Alliance of Heroic Champions delivers presents to kids with behavior issues on Christmas?”

“Why, indeed.” Rather than go in for another sandwich, Lodestar set the bag down, giving Donald her full attention. “Simply put, it’s because I don’t agree with the way Christmas is run. It would be one thing if Santa were fictional, instead of a real person running around out there, deciding who counts as ‘good’. Weighing the actions of adolescents with some perceived right of judgment. We’re not talking about fully actualized and independent adults making choices. These are kids. Children act out for a lot of reasons: poor boundaries at home, social pressures among their peers, even a simple inability to articulate their emotions outside of action. I’m not saying there’s no such thing as a bad apple, but most kids are *good* kids. They’re just dealing with an imperfect world.”

Lodestar rose up from her perch on the building’s edge, floating high enough to easily surveil the entire town.

“Do you think what the children who are already struggling really need is coal in their stocking? Yet another voice saying there’s something about them that’s just wrong. Naughty. *Bad*.”

Something almost like anger flickered along her face, and Donald fought to keep himself calm. With her power, if Lodestar got mad, there was truly no telling what she could do.

“Santa has to play by those rules, but I, *we*, don’t. We’re allowed to be the voice telling them that it’s never too late, that they can still make the right choices, that someone, somewhere out there believes they are worth the barest modicum of effort that a simple present demands. We’re able to

offer *hope*, rather than condemnation. That's the gift we get every holiday season, and it's one I treasure tremendously."

Donald nodded, the breakfast sandwich suddenly feeling heavy in his stomach. Fun as the night had been, even after putting together what they were doing, he'd never stopped and really considered what would prompt such actions. Yet Lodestar had not only spotted the issue on her own, she'd taken steps to remedy it. So often, the job of being a superhero felt like it revolved around action and adventure, but ultimately, their true task was caring for the people who trusted them.

That was what it meant to be a superhero.

Finishing his breakfast, Cyber Geek leapt from the building and activated the rocket pack on his back. He still had a few hours before his friends would be up; there was bound to be some good he could still do.

It wouldn't be until hours later, when recounting the story to his friends, that Cyber Geek would pause to wonder just what Lodestar meant about Santa being real.

Tori awoke on Christmas morning feeling surprisingly well. After her tussle, she'd expected some soreness, even with her body's exceptional healing, yet the sound of sizzling bacon roused a whole and hardy young woman from Ivan's couch. She'd planned on heading home, but after a sudden trip to the North Pole, rest was irresistible. Slowly extracting herself from the covers, Tori stumbled into the kitchen, where a pot of hot coffee was already brewed.

She poured a large mug, then took advantage of her immunity to being burned by downing the entire thing like a cup of water. After tossing back another, she added cream and sugar to her third, this one meant for actual enjoyment. Only then did Ivan look up from his pan of bacon to offer greetings. "Good morning."

"Has there ever been a morning that's actually good?" Tori grumbled. "Also, this may sound nuts, but did we go to the North Pole last night? I could have sworn it was real, except I've got no aches or pains, so overly real dream from bad eggnog seems like the next best explanation."

"It was real, or as real as things up there can ever be." Ivan pulled a piece of bacon from the pan to check its doneness, not bothering with tongs. "How did that possessed toy manage to hit you in the first place, despite being made of living flame?"

"More god damned magic," Tori muttered.

That earned a chuckle from Ivan, even as he started transferring the cooked strips of meat to a plate laden with paper towels. "Same principle. The spirit is gone, the magic of the True North has faded, and with it went the physical signs of your adventure."

“I get it: magic giveth, magic taketh-away. Do I ever hate that shit.”

Looking up, Ivan cast a telling glance out to the living room. “I don’t know. You may want to reserve that opinion until after you’ve opened your gift.”

Tori, who’d been creeping around to steal a piece of bacon, froze in her tracks. She’d forgotten about the present! With a very dignified saunter, repressing her instinct to scramble forward, Tori made her way back into the living room. Beneath the tree, she spotted her package, though the size seemed to have shifted somewhat through the night.

Ivan arrived only a few seconds behind her, so Tori saw no reason to wait. Ripping into the paper, she tore it away to reveal a garish green frame styled like a garland with twinkling lights. Ugly as it was, the sight also pricked at something in her memory, a distant echo of an image long forgotten. That was, until she turned the frame around and felt her breath catch in her throat.

“Something satisfactory, I assume?”

Not trusting herself to speak, Tori merely turned to show Ivan her present. It was a photograph taken at a mall Santa kiosk decades prior, two people with familiar features smiling as a grumpy young girl sat in Santa’s lap. Even glimpsing a version a few years younger than his own daughter, Ivan could see the seeds of the woman she’d grow into, though the scowl certainly helped.

Walking over, Ivan gently laid a hand on Tori’s shoulder, squeezing once. Neither excelled at emotional displays, but he was here if she needed him. For nearly five minutes they sat like that, before Tori felt in control enough to risk a few words. “How... how did they get this? I remember this hideous frame. I didn’t even want to go do the photo, I told them I was getting too old. We took this the last Christmas before... I thought it was gone with the rest of their stuff, lost to whatever vultures swooped in after they passed.”

“Christmas magic isn’t all possessed toys and ancient caverns,” Ivan reminded her. “You rendered aid in its time of need. A true gift was paid in return.”

“In that case, what did the Guardian of Christmas Magic earn for himself?” Tori was blatantly trying to steer the conversation toward less emotionally volatile topics, so Ivan happily obliged.

Leaving her side, he scooped up his own package from beneath the tree, tucked between the myriad of presents awaiting Beth and Rick, along with a few for Tori herself. “I admit, I’m curious too. The gifts almost make up for all the inconveniences that come with this role.”

Peeling away the paper, Ivan revealed a bright yellow rectangle over an inch thick. To Tori’s shock, Ivan’s eyes actually went wide, and he let out a small gasp. For him, that may as well have been a joyous scream to the rafters. “Well? Don’t keep me in suspense.”

With incredible care, Ivan turned the rectangle around, allowing Tori to see the front. On it was a series of blocky neon letters spelling out “AHC Afterschool Specials: Volume 6” with a lot of excessive squiggles and shapes surrounding the words. Even looking at it directly, Tori still took a solid five seconds to realize the yellow part was only the cover.

The actual gift was a VHS tape, which probably made it useless unless Ivan was a collector of antiquated technology. Sitting down, tape still in hand, Ivan explained, “During the mid-‘90s, the AHC had its hands in several pies, and an effort was made at creating wholesome, educational content for teachers to run in schools. They’re mostly forgettable, but Volume 6 is special. There’s no footage of it anywhere online, and every known copy has been destroyed.”

Tori couldn’t quite help being pulled in, no matter how silly that cover appeared. “What was on there? Did they catch some cape taking a drunk shit on set? Oh, or was there a crime captured in the background of the shot?”

“Better.” Ivan’s voice was barely above a whisper, like he feared someone might be listening. “Legend has it, Lodestar does an educational *rap*.”

“What? No. Noooooo,” Tori said, drawing out the last word.

“It was the nineties. Almost every public figure tried it at some point. But they didn’t have the resources to wipe their embarrassment out.” Ivan cradled his gift with obvious glee, and Tori had a hunch he’d be hunting down a VCR one way or another.

Looking down at her own gift, Tori suppressed a snuffle. Even though it had just begun, this was already shaping up to be one of the best Christmases she’d had since... well, since she was the little girl in the photograph.

It certainly helped that for the first time in a very long while, she had people to share it with.

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Christmas Day arrived in full force, finding a great many weary meta-humans greeting the morning. In a pleasant diner attached to a sizable truck stop, Johnny Three Dicks and Thuggernaut toasted their coffee mugs to Kristoph's glass of chocolate milk. No one would ever put their names on a list of "Nice" people, yet each felt the warm glow of contentment in their certainty the world had been made better by their hands.

Many miles away, Austin banged on Ellie and Kyle's doors, just as he had since he and Kyle were children. The excitement always kept him up, yet, determined to be a good boy, Austin had never allowed himself to rise before the sun. Once he did, however, his excitement was boundless. With his friends awakened, Austin paused outside the empty room, hand still half-extended, before starting work on breakfast.

There was no Lodestar to be seen as Penelope bolted out of her room, hurrying toward the Christmas tree. Only Helen, wearing a robe that had seen many better days, holding a mug that was arguably as much cream as it was coffee. Noble as the night's work always felt, it had once pained her not to get to see the kids' faces when they realized what awaited them. Now, she soaked in her daughter's joy as the wrapping paper flew, hoping the others were even a fraction as excited.

Within the AHC headquarters, where many of the superheroes lived, music streamed through the speakers and twinkling lights adorned the ceiling. Ren, Lucy, and Irene gathered with Donald in his room, all of them clad in comfortable clothes that would soon serve as pajamas. After the late night, Donald was looking forward to a long nap, but he could hold out a



little while longer. At least through breakfast and their Secret Santa exchange.

Professor Quantum presided over the morning breakfast on Vomisa, making a rare public appearance during one of his trips. This, too, was a matter of efficiency and morale, though it didn't hurt that the staff always prepared white-chocolate raspberry pancakes he greatly enjoyed. Food was a vessel for nutrition first and foremost, of course, but if he had to attend this event and eat anyway, there was no harm in a holiday indulgence.

Chaos was the name of the day for Beverly. Her entire extended family had gathered at their grandmother's house, as tradition demanded. Nearly a dozen small cousins generated constant yelling as they raced about, while several of her uncles were fighting about who'd made the best eggs, and the television was blasting a winter parade on full volume, as Grandma had trouble hearing but liked the announcers. Beverly reveled in every mundane minute, savoring the slice of normalcy in her often unruly life.

The joyful morning slowly gave way to a peaceful afternoon. After a quick visit to Doctor Mechanical, Ivan welcomed Beth and Rick, one child visibly more excited about the visit than the other. He dutifully pretended not to notice and embraced them both, leading the pair to a waiting lunch before they dove into the Christmas presents.

A groggy Tori finally rose again, having headed back to her own bed after opening presents with Ivan. She found that Chloe had whipped up quite a spread, and for a horrible moment, Tori feared she'd have to try and take down six entire dishes of *Chloe's* cooking. Given the choice, she'd have preferred to go a few more rounds with the possessed bear.

Thankfully, not long after Tori was up, their guests arrived. Austin, Kyle, and Ellie had all shown up for a neighborly celebration, and Chloe assured them that Beverly would be by a bit later. After opening some wine for the guests and a beer for herself, Tori started steeling her nerves to smile through what was sure to be... unique flavors. She was so distracted by the looming meal, Tori didn't even notice Kyle fiddling with a small gift, before hurriedly tucking it back into his pocket when her head started to turn. While Tori did catch the comforting pat Austin offered his friend, without context, she simply assumed it was a gesture of affection on a day known for encouraging them.

Indroga's festival ran through the streets. Mechanical monstrosities once solely designed with destruction in mind towered over their homes, blasting

candy and confections into the air at irregular intervals. The parade of marvels was designed as a testament to Tyranny's power as much as it was a celebration of the season, a reminder to anyone watching that these were the creations she'd built to merely entertain her citizens. Let them wonder, then, what sorts of inventions were awaiting those who crossed her.

The Guild of Villainous Reformation was comparatively quiet, having partied so hard the evening prior. No jobs were occurring, as the guild's council had approved none for that day. In truth, they'd almost never approved jobs on Christmas, save for a few rare exceptions. Some would argue that it was part of not overly antagonizing the capes; others would say it was simple courtesy for the holiday. And though most knew the real reason, none would speak it aloud: villains had people they loved and wanted to spend time with, too.

Well after her apartment party had wrapped and her stomach had settled, Tori headed out into the early evening, meeting up with Donald at Ridge City Grinders. Together, the pair swapped stories and caught up on life, though neither was able to share their previous night's adventures. That was all right, it was a boundary of their friendship that Tori had accepted when she chose to preserve it, despite their opposing occupations. Still, Tori did wish she could tell him about Twangle, the elves, and everything else hiding at the North Pole.

Though Ivan would have gladly spent all day with his children, teens always seemed to have other places to be. Rick was gone before the sun had come anywhere near setting, offering a half-excuse of going to see friends. As for Beth, one of her Starscout friends had invited her ice-skating with the cluster for a few hours, and she was visibly excited about the outing. After she'd been picked up, Ivan gathered one last bag of presents and headed across town.

Helen answered the door after two knocks, greeting him with a hesitant smile. Things hadn't been the same since the Wrexwren invasion, but they were steadily rebuilding a sense of comfort around each other. She noticed the presents poking out of his bag and rolled her eyes. "You trying to spoil my daughter?"

Gently, Ivan shook the bag. "I don't recall claiming that all of these were for her."

"Hmmm, I guess I can at least let you in for coffee, then." The playful smile on her lips suddenly faltered as Ivan walked past, humming a terribly

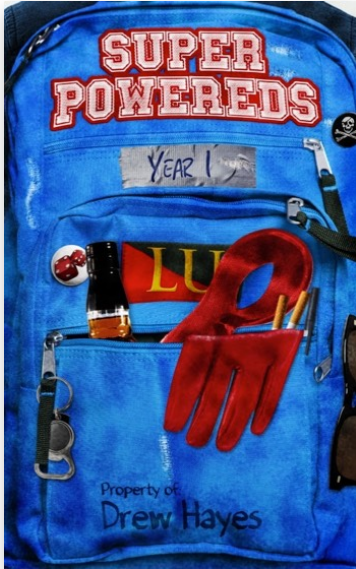
familiar tune beneath his breath.

Helen's face froze, mounting horror shining in her eyes. "Ivan... *where* did you hear that song? Ivan!"

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# ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Drew Hayes is an author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

Read or purchase more of his work at his site: [DrewHayesNovels.com](http://DrewHayesNovels.com)



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GORPPIES

DREW HAYES

# Corpies

by Drew Hayes

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## **Acknowledgements**

This book is for my dad, Lee Hayes. While he might not have a lot in common with Owen Daniels, to me he will always be as strong as Titan.

Special thanks as well to my beta readers, who made this novel better than it could have possibly been without their help. Thanks Priscilla Yuen, E Ramos E, and TheSFReader.



## Wait!!!

Hang on a second, you awesome reader, you. I know you're excited to get in to the book that you just purchased (or are inquisitively sampling), but there's a bit of context you need to know before moving forward.

First and foremost, you need to be aware that this book, *Corpies*, is a spin-off of my *Super Powered*s series. Now, while you will still be able to enjoy the tale even if you haven't read those other stories, you should be aware that there will be references to people and places that seem random but are in fact pointing back to the *Super Powered*s series. Just something to take the burden off your mind, assuming you panic that you missed chapters when you see stuff like that (like I do).

Secondly (and this part is really only relevant if you do read the *Super Powered*s series), this story occurs during the events of *Super Powered*s: Year 3, starting after the Lander HCP semester has begun and wrapping up a while before Intramurals. That's why there might be some allusions to impending things that you, as a caught-up reader, know have already occurred.

Lastly, though this has no bearing on the spin-off stuff, I just want to say thanks for picking up *Corpies*. Despite starting as a tentative Web serial side-project, this book has grown in to one of my favorites to work on over the years. I appreciate you taking a chance on it, and I sincerely hope you enjoy.

## Prologue

Owen sat in one of the waiting room's many reinforced chairs and flipped through an old *Capes & Cows* magazine. It detailed the rise of one of the latest crops of Heroes, fresh off their internships and making quite a splash in the world. Their costumes were crisp, their dialogue concise, their images squeaky clean. These were the kind of wholesome, homespun, moral warriors that would take the lead in creating a new world, free of immorality. These were the kind of Heroes the world needed more of: or at least that's the idea the reporter espoused.

It would have been vastly more impressive if Owen didn't know that two of the featured four were already dead. He'd heard one was in rehab upstate, and though the final member was still active, she wasn't quite so eager or wholesome anymore. She certainly didn't schedule in time for op-ed pieces with interviewers. Now she just focused on getting the job done. That was the trouble with old magazines. Media darlings rarely lived up to their initial hype, and for the ones who did, the eventual fall just became all the more catastrophic.

Owen had just set the magazine down when the door a few feet away flew open. A muscular man younger than Owen stepped out. He wore a bright red costume with yellow trim, a matching mask, and a cape that fell to just above his calves. Owen hoped this kid was a flier or a strongman, otherwise someone was going to make him regret that fluttering fashion choice. A couple of steps behind the costumed kid was another man, this one older, shorter, and sporting a significant paunch instead of a body rippling with muscle.

"Don't worry about a thing; you just go on home and relax," the smaller man assured the larger. "We'll get this whole mess cleaned up and fixed before you can say Bam Piff Zow."

The costumed Hero nodded his head and set off through the waiting room. His gaze lingered on Owen for a moment, the spark of recognition flickering through his eyes almost immediately dismissed. No way. Couldn't be Him. Must be a new guy who was a fan, paying homage with the outfit. He walked through the door without another glance; this man had more worrisome things on the brain.

“Good to see you, Lenny.” Owen rose from the chair and towered over the smaller man. From here he could see Lenny’s prominent bald spot. A different person might have gone for a toupee or a comb-over, or tried some radical drug to fix such vain failings. Not Lenny. He spent every day around people who were physically superior to him; if his ego were wrapped up in his looks, it would have hanged itself long ago.

“My stars, look at you,” Lenny muttered, taking in the massive form looming over him. He’d have almost sworn it was a few decades ago and this was the same fresh-faced newbie who was hot out of the HCP. Same chiseled frame, same red shirt and jeans, same dark wavy hair, same bright mask. The most notable differences were under the mask, though: a crooked smile that wasn’t as carefree, the stubble of a working man who didn’t have time to shave, tired green eyes that lacked the luster and hope of a new Hero. That might have worried others in Lenny’s field, but personally, he preferred his clients with the shine wiped off. They’d learned they weren’t invincible, and they made smarter choices because of that.

“Genetics is bullshit,” Lenny said at last. “I bet you don’t even have to watch what you eat.”

“Not really, no.”

“Hell, my doctor has me eating whole wheat and cheese curd every day for breakfast. Do you know what it takes to make that crap taste good?”

“No, what?”

“Damned if I have a clue, I was genuinely asking. Enough jawing in the waiting room; let’s go to the office.”

It was strangely comforting how little Lenny’s office had changed since Owen left the Hero world. The tacky décor, the oversized filing cabinets, the weathered globe that turned into a bar when you swiveled it, all of it was still there. What *had* changed were the posters on the walls. Lenny always kept his brightest stars up, the hot tickets constantly on display so that everyone who came in knew the kind of clientele this man catered to. A few of the posters were even framed. These were the ones that weren’t coming down, the Heroes Lenny considered “legendary”. Owen only knew of one framed poster Lenny had taken off the wall, and he didn’t hold it against the smaller man one bit.

“So,” Lenny said once he was situated behind his desk. “You want to come back to The Life.”

Owen smiled; he'd forgotten the way Lenny referred to working the Hero scene. The Life. It was actually a pretty apt phrasing. Being a Hero wasn't a nine-to-five; it dominated every aspect of who someone was. Even the parts they might wish it didn't.

"Yeah. I do."

Lenny ran a hand through his ever-thinning hair. "Listen, Titan, you know I never held the whole fiasco against you. Shit happens. If it didn't, I'd likely be out of a job. That said, time does not heal all wounds as far as public perception is concerned."

Owen appreciated Lenny trying to be diplomatic, skirting the details and not outright referring to what had happened as The Titan Scandal, as it had gone down in history. Still, it was an unnecessary nicety. They both knew what had happened, as did a vast majority of the nation, if not the world. Titan, the world-famous Hero with a family man image, had been caught by a hidden camera having sex with another Hero. Bad as that might have been on its own, what had compounded the issue was the fact that Titan's partner in the scandal, Tower, wasn't female. Infidelity was one thing, but closeted homosexuality, especially in those days. . . it had led to a fall from grace that was more akin to a plummet. What little of the Titan reputation that remained was almost entirely due to the effort of Lenny.

Heroes didn't need agents, technically speaking, any more than a cook needs butter to create a nutritionally-sound meal. However, most quickly found out that having a job in the public eye led to a lot of pressure, and people like Lenny made everything flow a lot more smoothly. He was a confidant, a fixer, a PR virtuoso, and a damage control specialist all heaped into a single roly-poly package. Still, even Lenny had his limits, as Owen had learned firsthand.

"That's okay. I know I'm not going to be walking back to a warm reception."

"You always did have a knack for understatement," Lenny said. "They'll come after you hard. A lot of people took what happened really personally, and there is nothing they'd love more than a chance to tear you apart."

"I know. Believe me, Lenny, no one knows better than me how hated I am."

"If only you were just hated. Hated I can work with. We play you as a

gruff counterpart to some guy whose image can tolerate it, do a turnaround over time, and presto, you're golden again. No, you're hated *and* held up as an icon by different groups. That gets people fighting—bickering, really—about some deeply-held beliefs. When you've got one man with two different images you can't shift one without impacting the other."

"I can deal with that."

"Of course you can, you're fucking Titan. But not so long ago this was enough to make you hang up the mask. Thankfully, your certification never expires, but getting you relicensed for Hero work will be a bear after so long, not to mention the headaches I'll get once the media gets a hold of it. Now, we go way back, and I like you, so that's shit I'm willing to wade through. But only if you can convince me that I won't do it only to see you walk off again three months later. What's changed?"

Owen sat silently for a few moments, his giant frame hunched in on itself. "My sons came to see me a few months ago."

"Oh yeah?"

"Yeah. This stays quiet, Lenny, dead quiet, because if you think I'm a PR shitstorm you have no idea what kind of hellhole they would open. Roy and Hershel are in the HCP themselves now and doing pretty good, from what I hear. "

"I didn't think the HCP took Powereds."

"They don't."

"Ho-lee-shit." Lenny turned and popped open his bar, poured himself a healthy measure of vodka over ice, and motioned for his prospective client to continue.

"Anyway, Roy was having trouble getting his ability to the next step, so Hershel hunted me down. I took a week, got them on the right path, then asked them to keep in touch. I'll spare you the finer points of the conversation, but they essentially told me to go fuck myself."

"Look, hurt feelings can run deep, especially at that age."

"See, that's the thing, Lenny. I don't think they were just hurt. I think they were right. Why should either one want to talk to me? Why should they care? I walked out on their mother and them; reasons be damned, I still did it. I could have made more of an effort. I could have tried to stay in some part of

their life. I fucked up. I let my own shit get in the way of people who needed me. That's a hard truth to accept, but I faced it. Unfortunately, that was when it occurred to me I had only scratched the surface on people I abandoned."

Lenny could already see where this was going. "Titan, come on; you're strong, but there're other Heroes on the job."

"It isn't about that, Lenny. It's about the fact that I could be out there, I could be helping people and making a difference, and instead I holed up in Colorado to lick my wounds. I missed out on the opportunity to be a real father, and I know I'm never going to be an A-list Hero from a popularity point of view, but I think it's time I stopped running away. I'm a strongman. We hit and we get hit. It's time for me to finally shake off that last one and start moving again."

Lenny sighed. "Shit, Titan. Why couldn't you give those kinds of speeches back in the day? I could have made you freaking king of the Heroes if you tugged the heart strings on command."

"What can you do now?"

"I can make a few calls," Lenny said slowly. "No promises, just a few calls. For an old friend. A favor, if you want it."

Owen gave him a smile, and for an instant Lenny was staring through time at the enthusiastic kid he'd first signed so very long ago.

"I'll take it."

# 1.

## Two Months Later

“You’re sure about this?” Lenny asked for somewhere around the ninth time, if Owen’s count was correct. “That’s the beauty of living behind a mask and a costume. Change those elements up and Poof! New Hero. It takes a little wiggling here and there, especially with guys of your proportions, but it’s nothing I can’t pull off.”

Owen shook his head solemnly. They were in Lenny’s office, cheesy decor surrounding the two very different men. Owen was suited up in his Titan costume, red shirt, red mask, and blue jeans all wrapped around nearly seven feet of solid muscle. As strong as he looked, he was actually far more powerful. Lenny, on the other hand, was still round and balding with a nose that looked like he’d tried to win a few boxing bouts by attacking his opponent’s fists with his face. Still, there was more than a touch of smarts and charisma in that foul-mouthed cherub’s eyes. Both were masters of their respective trades, though one had been out of the game for a long while.

“I’m not changing identities,” Owen said. “I’m coming back as Titan. If I don’t, then I feel like I’m still running. It might not make sense to you, but this is how I have to do it.”

Lenny ran his hand across the top of his head, touching more skin than hair by a large margin. Habits didn’t die easily, though, even if follicles did. “I was afraid you were going to say that. You know that makes things harder, right? The other way would open up a lot more options.”

“The options for going at it the right way are the ones I want,” Owen insisted.

“Don’t say I didn’t warn you.” Lenny slid a manila envelope across the desk to his client. “Even with your license reinstated, there weren’t a lot of people clamoring to have you on their team. You come with more heat than most folks are willing to take.”

“Solo Heroes exist,” Owen said.

“Not for you they don’t,” Lenny countered. “We let you go solo and that’s how you’ll be until the end. You’ll look like an outcast, the guy that no

one wanted after his scandal. People like me will use your story as a cautionary tale to keep younger Heroes in line.”

“But no one *does* want me,” Owen pointed out.

“Why would you bring that up? My ulcer isn’t bad enough this week without you reminding me what we’re trying to pull off here? You’re a hurtful man and you should be ashamed,” Lenny chastised. “Besides which, you’re wrong. The team in that folder agreed to take you, so at least some people want you.”

Owen took the clue to flip open the folder. As soon as he began reading, a frown formed at the corner of his mouth, visible just below the bottom of his skintight mask. The frown deepened the longer he read, until finally his gaze rose from the pages and across the desk to his agent.

“Corpies? Are you shitting me?”

“Oh, I’m sorry, did my months of trying to impress upon you how few your options were not provide a slight clue that you were getting the bottom of the shit-bucket? And don’t call them that. The technical term is Privately Employed Emergency Response Supers, or PEERS if you don’t have all day.”

“Come on, Lenny, these people aren’t even Heroes.” Owen dropped the file onto the desk. “Why would I be on a team of corpies?”

Try as he might, Owen couldn’t imagine what sort of justification Lenny would use for this proposal. Corpies were Supers who hadn’t gone through the screening or training to get their Hero Certifications and therefore were not allowed to confront criminal Supers. However, through some loophole maneuvering and fancy legal footwork, it had been established that a Super did not need a Hero Certification to assist in any emergency response operation that didn’t involve combat. This charge was led by corporations that yearned to get their logos emblazoned on the capes of champions doing good, saving innocents, and spreading the word about how this particular laundry soap got your whites the whitest. Rarely did a corpie attain any real popularity; however, the few times they had gotten a following had been so profitable that companies eagerly rolled the dice and kept right on paying to keep their names on Supers. Though many Heroes considered them worthless hacks who couldn’t cut it in the Hero game, the fact remained that having them on hand usually did more good than harm, so their continued existence was tolerated with minor grumbling. But that didn’t mean Owen wanted to babysit a damn group of them.



“Why? Because in order for them to function as an independent team, working in their own fancy headquarters, responding to various disasters and calls, they have to have a Hero Liaison on staff. Someone to bat cleanup if things get messy or trouble shows up. This team, as luck would have it, just lost their Hero to retirement. No others are stepping forward, so they either had to take you on or go back to working in the basement of a police station where the lights don’t work and it smells like piss. Those were their options: piss smell or you.”

“But-”

“AND,” Lenny said, raising his voice and rising slightly off his chair, “I had to wheel and deal to make it happen. It was you and a luxury high-rise loft, or no you and a dank piss-scented basement, and I had to *convince* them to take you. Are you getting the picture here?”

“Then forget it,” Owen replied. “If no team wants me then I’ll go solo after all. Let me be a story. Let everyone call me an outcast and a failure. Better that than chaperoning a bunch of corpies.”

“That is your prerogative,” Lenny said, his temper cooling as he lowered himself back into his seat. “You have the right to go at this alone. But if you do, then you’re doing it completely alone.”

A pang of uncertainty smacked Owen in the gut. “What are you saying?”

“I’m saying that if you go solo, I’m out. I’ll finish the paperwork to make you official again, and that’s it.”

“What the hell, Lenny? Suddenly it’s my way or the highway? What ever happened to finding what works best for the Hero?” Owen resisted the urge to jump out of his own seat, only because he was afraid he might crack the floor.

Lenny didn’t yell back this time. Instead, he took an antacid from his desk drawer and dropped it into a glass of water with a fizzy plop.

“I am thinking about what’s best for you. We worked together for a long time, back in the day. I know you, and that’s why I’m telling you that you need a team. The family man image we sold you as worked because you *are* a family man. You need people around who depend on you. They give you strength. They are what push you past your hardest moments. Last time you went off on your own, your funk lasted over a decade and didn’t break

until your sons called you a fucker. You need a team, Titan. Without one, it's just a matter of time until it all becomes too much and you fall apart again. And I'm not hanging around for it this time."

Owen felt his indignation morph in to shame. He'd been calling Lenny a quitter when he was the one who'd walked away. Lenny was doing what he did for all his clients: just trying to make sure they were put in the best position to stay happy and employed. He was watching out for Owen, even after Owen had nearly cost Lenny his reputation all that time ago.

Owen reached across and picked back up the folder. "Are they expecting me?"

"You report for duty at nine tomorrow morning," Lenny informed him.

"Seems late."

"They have a photo shoot at seven."

Owen resisted the urge to groan, but only barely.

## 2.

Owen stared up at the building, admiring the way it jutted into the sky as though it were trying to spear clouds. On days with the right weather, it probably succeeded. He adjusted the duffel bag on his shoulder more out of nerves than necessity. Even as fully as it was packed, the bag was nowhere near heavy enough to actually cause him discomfort. Most of his possessions had been stored back at his place in Colorado, though some had been sent ahead to this building via courier. The things in the bag he never trusted to anyone else. They were too important to be risked.

“Titan?”

The voice snapped Owen out of his marveling and brought him back to reality. He wasn’t dressed as Titan currently; instead he wore simple clothes and a generic gray mask. Wearing such masks was standard practice for Heroes who didn’t want to be “in character” but still needed to go places without showing their face. It was inconvenient; however, it beat the hell out of having one’s identity blown. Since he wasn’t wearing his Titan costume, though, it meant this was the man who had known he was coming. Or someone who was a really good guesser.

The fellow who had spoken was tall and lean, wearing a suit that was conservative enough to say corporate but expensive enough to show he was high on the food chain. His glasses and watch were designer, and his hair had been expertly styled. Owen suspected he was not going to like this person.

“You’re Harold?”

“Mr. Greene, if you don’t mind,” the man replied.

“Whatever you say.” Owen hefted his bag again. “We going inside?”

“Of course,” Mr. Greene said. “If you’d be so kind as to follow me.”

Mr. Greene and Owen walked through the front doors, large glass ones that opened into a sprawling lobby that seemed to be made of marble. All around them other people in suits and business appropriate outfits scuttled about, doing things that they no doubt believed were of the utmost importance. In the center of the lobby, just ahead of a long row of elevators, was a circular station where a pair of guards sat. Mr. Greene stopped at this

station and handed them a card extracted from his breast pocket.

“We’ll get your keycard and I.D. done this afternoon,” Mr. Greene informed him. “You’ll need them at all times while on premises, otherwise you won’t be permitted access.”

“That so?” Owen said the words casually, but as he spoke his eyes swept the room, years of experience alerting him to the bits and bobbles of security a casual observer wasn’t supposed to see. “Have to say, the tazing system built into the floor wouldn’t really slow me down, and the knockout gas dispensers you’ve got disguised as fire alarms would only tickle my throat. Now, the pulse cannon you’ve made to look like a potted plant, that might set me back a few steps.”

“Impressive,” Mr. Greene commented. “I suppose there is more to you than size and reputation.”

“I aim to please.”

Once they passed the security guards, Mr. Greene flashed his card in front of an elevator near the end of the line. Its doors whooshed open and the two men stepped inside.

“All this for one team?” Owen asked as the elevator began to rise.

“Don’t be silly. This building houses offices for multiple companies, all owned, at least partially, by Mordent Holdings. Each member of the team is sponsored by at least one of our companies, so we made a few floors into facilities for them. We find it best if our representatives stay on site.”

“You mean where you can keep an eye on them,” Owen said.

“We provide housing, food, facilities, and entertainment, all at no deduction from their salaries. I’d say that’s quite a generous situation for them,” Mr. Greene shot back.

“Because we all know corporations love doing things from the goodness of their hearts.” Owen fiddled with his duffle bag once more. “Look, I’m not telling you how to run your company or your team, just calling it like I see it.”

“I’d suggest you call it more quietly.” Mr. Greene’s eyes never wavered from the climbing numbers on the elevator’s display. “We approved taking you on as the Hero Liaison because it was deemed to be an overall net gain. Should that equation change, we may need to revisit your position’s

feasibility.”

“Yeah yeah, toe the line like a good boy or I’m out on my ass. If you don’t mind me asking, what made you decide to take me on, anyway? I’m not exactly the best PR magnet these days.”

“Mordent Holdings has recently received negative publicity at the hands of discrimination lawsuits alleging we create a hostile working environment for women and homosexuals. Some of the recordings played in court and leaked online were particularly damning. As part of our efforts to assure the public such culture will not be tolerated, we’re making strides to earn back the trust of the female and LGBTQ communities. Hiring you was one of many examples of our new corporate culture.”

The elevator dinged and the doors slid open, revealing a carpeted hallway leading to a single door at the end. Owen peered down its depths, counting at least four more security measures designed to take down anything from humans to rhinos to Supers with enhanced durability. These people didn’t skimp on security, at least.

“So you give me a second chance and hope the public will give you one. Not bad. What about the rest of the team? They picked to smooth out scandals too?”

“No, they were chosen for their abilities, appeal, marketability, and talents. There are four, aside from yourself: Galvanize, Hexcellent, Bubble Bubble, and Zone. Galvanize is their leader, since he has the most training and experience.” As he spoke, Mr. Greene stepped out of the elevator and began walking down the hall. “Don’t worry; the system recognizes biometrics, and anyone accompanied by me is considered friendly. We’ll get you programmed in when we do your keycard.”

Owen contemplated telling this man that he hadn’t hesitated out of worry for himself, he had been more afraid of breaking something if the system went after him. He decided to stay quiet, however. No need to rock the boat too much on the first day. Besides, there was zero doubt Mr. Greene was the kind of man who’d read up on Titan. He knew it would take more than standard safeguards to bring down this near-giant of a man.

“Anything else I should know before we go in?” Owen followed his escort off the elevator, noting that it closed swiftly as soon as he exited.

“Only this: even though you are not sponsored by any of our companies, by aligning with people who are, you become a de facto

representative of us. We expect you to take that seriously and behave appropriately.”

“Me? I’m always appropriate,” Owen said, making an expression as innocent as he could behind the gray mask.

“Glad to hear it.”

“Glad to say it. Now let’s go on in, fuckwad.”

The look on Mr. Greene’s face was worth the earful Owen knew he’d be getting later. With a slight chuckle and a genuine smile, he took the last several steps and opened the door.

### 3.

Owen's first headquarters hadn't been much. Whether it was a Hero, a doctor, an MBA, or a bartender, a recent college grad is a recent college grad. True, Owen had made a little money during his internship under Citadel, his Hero mentor; however, he'd likely have made better cash waiting tables during that time. The end result was that when his first team formed, their financial resources were limited. Their headquarters/living area had been a near-condemned old mattress store that they'd erected half-assed partitions in. It had been derelict, dirty, and largely unsafe. Still, he carried fond memories of that time in his life, if only because both he and the people he worked with were still young and idealistic enough that the future looked like a bright and wonderful thing.

His first thought upon walking into this new team's headquarters was that if his first team had been able to get a place like this, they would have taken a lot fewer calls in favor of staying home and being comfortable. The front doors opened in to an expansive living room. Next to it was a large kitchen, gleaming with stainless steel appliances. Windows lined the far wall, looking out toward the city and providing a breathtaking view. The floor was carpeted with lush, soft material. In the living room, a gigantic television stood in the center of an entertainment unit, surrounded by various videogame systems and flanked by a wraparound leather couch. A young woman with ink-black hair and makeup- pale skin mashed on a controller and a small male figure on said giant screen plummeted down a spiked pit to his doom.

"Fucking bullshit horsecock dickgarglers," the woman swore, spitting it all out as nearly one word. She jammed a button on the controller and the screen reloaded, the digital man immediately resurrected.

"Keep it down," said another woman, this one sitting on an end of the couch so far away it faced the door rather than the television. Her skin was pale too, though it was also dotted with freckles at irregular intervals. Her carefully-styled copper hair was swept to the side, purposely not obscuring her line of vision as she flipped the page on her magazine.

"Why don't you go try to suck a gig out of a producer's cock?" the other woman shot back.

"Why don't both you notice we have a guest and show a little a

class?” said a new voice, this one from a young man emerging out of the kitchen with peeled orange slices in hand. He turned to greet Owen and Mr. Greene with a wide, practiced, and dazzling smile. His wavy brown hair and boy-next-door features only completed the effect, making him appear affable, friendly, and immediately accessible. “I’m sorry about that. I’m Galvanize, the team leader.”

“Titan,” Owen replied, taking the young man’s hand in a firm shake. It had been a lot of work learning to shake hands without shattering bones, but he’d perfected it ages ago.

“The one playing video games is Hexcellent, and the woman reading is Bubble Bubble,” Galvanize said, pointing to each as he spoke.

Hexcellent paused the game to give Owen a half-hearted wave, turning in her seat rather than standing up. She was lean, slender all over, but with the type of tight muscle one saw in athletes and Heroes. Her face was probably pretty, but since it was obscured by several piercings, dark lipstick, and so much eye makeup that it even coated her cheekbones, it was hard to tell. She wore all black and had a tattoo of some bat-like creature on her left shoulder.

Bubble Bubble, on the other hand, was especially put together. She wore clothes that had the kind of simple elegance that looked ordinary but Owen knew actually cost a dump truck of money. She had a more classic beauty, the kind one might find in the Marilyn Monroe era. This one, at least, gave a smile and said “Hello” before turning back to the magazine in her lap.

“Where’s Zone?” Mr. Greene asked, interrupting the already awkward introductions.

“In the gym,” Galvanize replied. “His exercise quota is higher than ours, after all.”

“Of course. That is acceptable then, just be sure he is introduced to Titan when he finishes,” Mr. Greene instructed. He turned his attention to Titan. “I’ll send someone to help you get set up in an hour or two. In the meantime, settle in and meet your new team.”

With not so much a “good luck,” Mr. Greene turned around and walked through the doors, which closed with a whooshing sound afterward.

“Isn’t he just a ray of sunshine,” Owen muttered.



“You get used to him,” Galvanize said. “Why don’t you get comfortable, take off your mask and shoes? Can I get you something to drink?”

At the mention of his mask, Owen’s eyes immediately went to the glass, which was so clear it barely registered as present. Galvanize saw where he was looking.

“Don’t worry; it only looks that way from our side. It’s custom. Durable beyond durable and impossible to see through from the outside.”

Owen trusted Galvanize’s words; however, unmasking in an unfamiliar place was something every bit of his life’s experiences told him not to do. Besides, he was going to have to leave soon to go get his access card and whatnot. Better to be masked in case the person coming to get him had access.

“I’m fine for now. As for the drink, what kind of beers do you have?”

“Oh, I’m so sorry, none of us are allowed to have alcohol,” Galvanize told him. “Part of our contracts and health requirements. I can offer you fresh squeezed guava juice, mango juice, specially made vitamin-infused water-”

“Water is fine,” Owen said, reeling at how kids this young could be okay with being banned from beer. Afterward, he chastised himself; these were accomplished professionals in their own right, he didn’t need to start thinking of them as kids just because he was old.

“Coming right up.” Galvanize walked to the kitchen and returned with a colorful bottle mere moments later. “So, since you’re new here, what would you like to know?”

“Let’s just start with the basics.” Owen grabbed a chair in a part of the living room not dominated by the giant couch where the two women were still largely ignoring him. “What are everyone’s powers?”

“A perfectly great place to start,” Galvanize agreed enthusiastically. “To go around the room, Hexcellent has the ability to summon creatures out of thin air.”

“Demons,” Hexcellent corrected, not looking away from her game.

“They are somewhat scary looking, and given the goth image her advertisers pay for, we would like it if you referred to them as demons,” said Galvanize, soothing his teammate while shooting Owen an apologetic look.

Summoners weren't too common. Owen had only met a few in his Hero career. Of course, the term was a bit of a misnomer. What they actually did wasn't summoning, it was creating an animate energy construct. It worked the same as people who could duplicate themselves, only instead of a personal copy, they formed something else. Most only had a few things they could create: the complexity to form one was so intense that having more than a couple of options made it too muddled to keep straight.

"How many can she summon?"

"I got three," Hexcellent answered from the couch.

Three wasn't bad. It was definitely HCP grade. Owen made a mental note to find out more about her power later, then motioned for Galvanize to continue.

"Bubble Bubble can create energy spheres that are pretty durable, and she can even move them with her mind. Not terribly fast, so we can't use them for rapid transport, but they are quite helpful in getting people out of high places and the like."

Evidently Bubble Bubble saw no need to correct Galvanize's assessment, as she continued to read quietly.

"Zone is in the gym, but his ability is basically enhanced agility, strength, and reactions. He's not at the level of really powerful Supers, but from the human perspective he's the best athlete alive. That's why he picked that name, because it's like he's always in the zone," Galvanize said. "Which leaves me. Aside from a nearly negligible side-effect of minor enhanced durability and strength, my main power is to give people a little extra push. I can amp them up and bring them to their peak."

"You're an *enhancer*?" Owen's eyes went wide. Enhancers were rare, damned near mythical Supers who could increase the strength of a person's power.

"Not a true one, no. I just bring people to their own physical best, and I have absolutely no effect on people's abilities. Again, it's all physical. I can't make them better than they normally would be, just take them to the maximum of their own level. It's like if you were a car, and the absolute best you could get up to, with ideal handling, was one hundred and ninety miles per hour, I would jump you to that speed. A real enhancer would bump you to, like, three hundred."

“I see. So when you use this ability of yours, anyone you target is suddenly going at maximum strength, speed, et cetera, within the limits of what their body can physically do?”

“You got it,” Galvanize said. “It doesn’t last long, but it’s made the difference a few times in helping get people to safety.”

“I want you to listen to me very, very carefully,” Owen said, leaning in slightly so that he was towering over Galvanize, even while they both sat. “Never use that power on me. Never. No matter what. Are we clear?”

“I . . . okay,” Galvanize mumbled, clearly taken aback. “There’s no shame in needing a push on occasion, though.”

“My worry is not that I will need a push. It is that I am incredibly strong and have worked for years to make sure I am in total control of that strength. If you suddenly jack me to maximum power then I don’t know how much destruction I’ll cause, but it will be a lot. Now, are we clear?” Owen repeated.

“We’re clear,” Galvanize replied.

#### 4.

Owen surveyed his new room. It was large: not that he was surprised by this, but aside from the few boxes that had been shipped from Colorado, its size made the space seem surprisingly sparse. A bed in the corner, dresser by the far wall with a small television perched on top, and a desk across from the door dominated by a monitor and keyboard. Upon further inspection, it only seemed under-furnished compared to the opulence that had been present everywhere else.

After basic introductions, Galvanize had shown him around. The area set aside for their residence consisted of three floors. Below the elevator entrance was the gym, a sprawling, state-of-the-art facility with enough equipment to accommodate a team of Olympic hopefuls. Unfortunately, since none of his new team had supremely advanced strength, there were no ultra-dense weights that Owen could use. He didn't mind that too much, though. Part of his ability kept his muscles from atrophying, so it wasn't as though he'd get weaker without training. If the need arose, he could always have someone ship his old weight set from Colorado over. He'd just have to pick a company that didn't charge by the pound.

The gym level also housed a large room outfitted with various sandbags, movable platforms, and mock-building fronts. Galvanize had explained to Owen that this was the room where they honed their rescue skills, doing drills through constantly-changing scenarios to make sure they were on top of their game. Here Owen had met Zone, a tan young man with frosted tips, a dazzling smile, and a body-fat percentage so low it had to be unhealthy. They'd exchanged pleasantries then Zone had hustled off to shower before an appearance promoting a skateboard company he represented. From the speed at which the younger Super moved, Owen suspected he was less than thrilled to have this new addition to their team. Owen didn't really mind; he wasn't exactly dancing at the idea of being here himself, after all.

The middle floor was the one where he'd entered. Aside from the living room and kitchen there was a large dining room, a conference room, and an office with several professional-grade computers, printers, and the like. Galvanize explained that this was so anyone who needed to print out headshots or other such paraphernalia before an appearance could do so in the

comfort of their own home. Evidently they had formerly outsourced such tasks, but it had turned out that doing them in-house was far more cost and time efficient.

The last floor was their living quarters: five large bedrooms, private bathrooms, a small nook with a coffee bar, and a sealed door. Owen had asked about the sealed door, which according to Galvanize was a high-tech area that only upper-management was allowed to access. Evidently, inside was a variety of gadgets and technology they were only permitted to use during training and missions. For a brief moment Owen contemplated snapping the metal door down with a minor exertion of effort, then thought better of it. It was only his first day, and he'd promised Lenny he'd try and be on good behavior. Given the abundant wealth of the team Owen was now on, he suspected his manager had pulled more than a few strings to make this happen. He needed to play nice, at least until he knew if he could handle this place or not.

Once the tour was done, they headed back to the main floor, where a pretty woman with a notepad was waiting for Owen. She took him back through the building, down to a normal business floor, and set about the task of registering him in the system. Stacks upon stacks of forms were signed, so many that Owen nearly spaced out and used his real name several times. Heroes' code names were, for purposes of legal contracts, considered acceptable alternatives to their own names. This had come about as more Heroes sought to enter private industry based on their Hero credentials but were not willing to compromise their secret identities. The only exception to this rule was for Heroes who inherited a legacy name, a name used already by a previous Super. They had to add a number after their signatures, distinguishing their identities, so that they were not bound by contracts or agreements their predecessors had signed.

After the seemingly endless forms, he'd been taken to a different area where he was forced to step into a strange machine that catalogued his biometrics, which would in turn allow him access to his new home. Then he was given a badge and card for entry into the building. Owen could not, for the life of him, understand why they insisted on taking a picture for his badge even though he was wearing a mask. He'd pointed this out, even offered to go back and change into his Titan mask so that it would be consistent, but his guide had merely shushed him down and assured him this was all part of standard procedure and had to be done in a precise way. Owen tried once more, pointing out it made no sense. The woman agreed, then told him to sit

in front of the camera and not to smile, because that would make the picture harder to recognize. Owen gave up and complied.

Now, at last, he was done for the day. Officially registered, he was a part of this team in every legal way. He might have made an effort to connect with them more, but by the time he finished, everyone was out doing various appearances. Owen wondered if they spent every day like this, and if so, how they were ever around to respond in time to emergencies. He needed to see what these kids could do, and soon, otherwise when they finally did go on a call he'd have no idea how to treat them if something went wrong. It was an issue he'd try and remedy tomorrow.

Owen carefully unpacked his duffel bag containing the possessions too important to trust to a courier service. First were his Titan costumes. He kept six of them so that if one was dirty or in need of repair he had spares on hand. They were made from hardy material, but Supers like him were often put in situations that not even technology-enhanced cloth could stand up to. Next came a large metal box with a strange, orb-shaped lock on it. Inside were a variety of trinkets and trophies from his first round of Hero days. Some were too dangerous to let out of his sight, but most just held too much sentimental value.

The final item extracted from his bag was a picture frame. Inside it were two photos set side by side. The first showed a younger Owen and a small boy in a junkyard, the boy proudly holding a washing machine over his head. The second was Owen and another boy, this one noticeably heavier, clutching a spelling bee trophy in his hands. In both photos, one could easily make out traces of Owen's strong face in the children's features.

Owen carefully set this frame on his desk, next to the monitor. Now, he was home.

## 5.

“This is stupid,” Hexcellent complained loudly, hands incessantly tugging on her sweatshirt as she tried to get comfortable in the unfamiliar garb. “You’re not our fucking leader; you’re just here as a token Hero so we can do our job. We don’t need to prove shit to you.”

“Hexcellent, that’s enough,” said Galvanize, his tone gentle but firm.

“No, it’s okay, I don’t blame her for calling bullshit,” Owen replied, his own chest bare as none of the sweatshirts he found in the gym were large enough to fit him. As it was, the sweatpants he’d found only came halfway down his calves, looking as though they’d been meant as capris.

The first thing that morning, Owen had found Galvanize to request a full team meeting. Galvanize had complied and gathered everyone in the gym less than an hour later. Unfortunately, since it was an official meeting, the rules demanded they wear their official team sweats, rather than whatever was comfortable and fit them best. Currently they were all standing around in the part of the gym designed for rescue simulations, eyes set on the now unmasked newcomer in their midst.

Walking in maskless had been a tough decision for Owen, one he’d ultimately realized was inevitable. Teamwork hinged on trust. They had it with each other; he could see that in their body language. As the new guy, he would have to earn it. Showing them his face was a small but necessary step in that process.

“I took the time to read up on all of you last night before bed. You have good response rates, excellent percentages of civilians saved, and zero unauthorized encounters with criminal Supers. The first two are good, but the last one struck me as odd. Given that nearly half of the incidents you responded to last year were caused by criminal Supers, it seems like you’d at least have needed to retreat or work around one at some point.”

“We don’t take unnecessary risks,” Zone said. Even wearing dumpy gray sweats, the man still looked as though he’d walked in from fashion shoot. “If Mirror Fog suspected any criminal Super involvement, we kept our distance until it was clear.” Mirror Fog had been their last Hero on staff, now retired to somewhere tropical and pretty.

“That’s because Mirror Fog’s ability allowed him to discover if one was at the scene of the emergencies,” Owen pointed out. “I don’t have that power, which means when we go on calls, there will be a very real chance of running into a criminal Super.”

“Sounds like your problem,” Hexcellent said.

“It is my problem. But getting civilians out of the danger zone is yours. That’s why I need to see what you each can do. It will tell me whether to call for a full retreat or have you keep helping people while I handle the situation.”

“Technically, that would be my call,” Galvanize said.

“With all due respect, no, it wouldn’t.” Owen phrased his reply as carefully as he could. He liked Galvanize. The kid seemed earnest in his efforts to help, but it was important to make things clear from the get go. “Most of the time, yes, you’re the leader and I respect that. But the minute we have to deal with some Super causing trouble, I’m in command. I’ve got the training and experience to make those kinds of calls.”

“Mirror Fog never tried to pull rank on us like that,” Zone snapped.

“Mirror Fog kept you away from other Supers, so it never came up,” Owen countered. “Our goal here is the same; we don’t want anyone to get hurt. The difference is that when things go wrong, you have to worry about civilians and I have to worry about you.”

The debate might have gone on longer, but at that moment, Bubble Bubble stepped forward and made a gesture at one of the dummies. A blue-tingled sphere appeared around the false person and began moving upward slowly.

“They’re slow, and they only get slower the more bubbles I try to move at once,” she said, her tone as even as it had been when reading her magazine. “At best, I could move one across a football field in two minutes. At worse, it would be around ten. The largest sphere I can create is big enough to hold around five people or one sedan-sized car. I can partially engulf large objects without destroying them, but that leaves the bubble’s integrity extremely compromised. ”

“How many can you conjure at once?” Owen asked.

“Up to five, but any more than three and the durability begins to



degrade,” Bubble Bubble answered.

“I see, and how durable are they before that happens?”

“They’ve stopped bullets, repelled flames, and taken large chunks of debris falling on them without giving way. But if you would like to test for yourself, feel free.” Another gesture and a sphere roughly five feet wide materialized in front of Owen.

“You read my mind,” Owen said, looking the bubble up and down. The thing about energy barriers people often failed to realize was that in order to stop something physical, force had to be exerted on it. Force flowing one way meant it could flow back the other, so while energy barriers were resistant to physical attacks, enough strength behind a blow could still shatter them.

Owen went slow, first doing nothing more than giving it a one-fingered thump. The sphere rippled, but held firm. Next he made a loose fist with his hand and struck it with a knocking motion, as though he were rapping on someone’s door. The rippling was far more evident this time, yet still the bubble held. The fingers in his hand grew closer as his fist tightened. When he struck this time it was like he was pounding on a door, a hammer of flesh trying to pierce the obstacle before it.

The bubble shattered in a bright burst of energy, whooshing sounds and a surge of heat accompanying the event.

“What the hell, B.B.? I thought your bubbles were supposed to be tough. Gramps there barely even touched it,” Zone chided.

“No, it was surprisingly strong,” Owen corrected. “The force I used on that last blow was roughly equivalent to it being hit by a speeding car.”

“Sounds about right for the reaction it generated.” Bubble Bubble made a quick motion with her hands to drop the suspended dummy everyone had forgotten about.

“Horseshit it does; that was barely a punch, even for an old man,” Hexcellent said.

“Then I say it’s time we tested your power next,” Owen replied. “I think this old man may just surprise you. Unless you’re afraid to put your power where your mouth is.”

“Bring it on, Gramps.” Hexcellent evidently had no qualms about

stealing the nickname Zone had used. “I’ve always wanted to show up one of you fancy-ass Heroes.”

## 6.

“You should walk more to the center of the room,” Galvanize advised. “So there’s space to move about.”

“If you say so.” Owen wasn’t too worried about needing to dodge, but stranger things had happened in his life. A few large steps brought him to the center of the unobstructed area with ample space around him. Hexcellent made no such motions.

“Aren’t you coming?” Owen called to the dark-haired woman.

“I don’t get my hands dirty, I’ve got people for that,” Hexcellent replied. “Let me demonstrate.”

“No.” Galvanize held up a hand and Hexcellent, to her credit, froze in place instantly. “I know what you’re about to do, and no. Show him the other two first. This is supposed to be a full assessment, not you trying to prove a point.”

“Fiiiiiiiiiiiiine,” Hexcellent agreed, drawing out the word into a whine. “I’ll start from the bottom. My smallest demon is Impers. We use him for recon and message relaying.” She stuck out her hand and exerted a minor bit of focus. Next to Owen, a small creature appeared in a puff of red smoke.

It was about a foot tall, human-shaped with red skin and diminutive horns on its head. Large, bat-like wings nearly as long as it was tall extended from its back, and a three-inch tail swept from side to side out of its rear. The creature made a chittering noise then leapt into the air. Owen was surprised with the grace it had in flight; it moved through the air with precision and speed. Impers circled the room four times then landed on Hexcellent’s shoulder and made the chittering noise again.

“How is that thing used for messages?” Owen asked. “It can’t talk.”

“‘It’ is a he, and we worked out a system,” Hexcellent explained. “Impers can understand the questions we ask him, plus he can control the clicks he makes. One click means yes, two means no, three means follow me, and four means run like hell. As long as you ask the right questions, it’s pretty effective.”

“Useful,” Owen said, trying his best to hide the surprise at this

creature being any gender, let alone male. Still, since it sprang from the summoner's mind, no one was more familiar with it than she. "Anything else I should know?"

"Impers is the smartest of my summons, so he can take the most complex directions. The others make noise, but they have to be ordered more directly. Impers excels in situations where we're trying to locate people who are trapped, since he can remember where he sees them and point to it on a map. He's frailer than the other two, but fireproof. All of them are fireproof, actually."

The fireproof part didn't shock Owen at all. "Okay, what's next?"

Impers vanished in the same smoke he'd appeared in. Another motion from Hexcellent and a much larger cloud of red smoke appeared near Owen. Out of this came a creature roughly five feet tall with the head of a vulture atop a hunched body. Its feet were taloned and in place of arms or wings were two long, translucent white blades in the shape of scythes.

"Her name is Huggles," Hexcellent informed Owen.

"Huggles?"

"I was feeling a bit feisty and sarcastic when I created her," she admitted. "Anyway, those blades on her arm are sharp enough to cut through most metals, and she's got the strength to wield them. She's most useful for getting people out of cars, sawing through debris, that sort of thing."

"I see. Mind having her strike me?"

"I can, but it won't prove anything," Hexcellent said. "Huggles can't cut through anything stronger than steel, and even that gives her trouble. I'd assume a veteran Hero like you is at least that tough."

"None the less, I'd prefer if you did." Owen stuck out his left arm and left it there, freely exposed.

"Have it your way. Huggles, cut his arm!" Hexcellent yelled. The words had no sooner left her mouth than the bird-thing whirled into action, again moving with more grace than its form should allow. She swung both arm-blades down in a smooth slice, striking two places on Owen's forearms. As soon as the blades met his skin, the motion ceased completely. He'd never expected Huggles to be powerful enough to move him, but he was surprised by the amount of strength the demon could muster. It was good to know this

thing had some power behind it.

“Not bad,” Owen complimented. “I take it there’s one left?”

“Yup, and I saved the best for last.” This time Hexcellent’s motions were slower, and there was a noticeable delay between Huggles’ disappearance and the next demon’s cloud of smoke. Once it appeared, though, it was impossible to miss. The cloud was huge, and Owen caught the faint scent of brimstone in his nostrils. Once the smoke cleared, he found himself in the rare position of looking up.

This monster stood over seven and a half feet tall, likely eight if one included the large, black horns jutting upward from its forehead. Thick, chitinous black plates covered much of its body, concentrated on the disproportionately large arms, the broad chest, and the thick legs ending in large hooves. Its face was dog-like, black sharp teeth in its muzzle and a pair of glowing red eyes above the snout. Any monster movie company would have paid top dollar for this creature to appear in one of their films, assuming they could keep the rest of the cast from pissing themselves.

“His name is Big Henry,” Hexcellent supplied helpfully. “His job is heavy lifting. Clearing rubble, moving cars, holding up support beams, that sort of thing. More or less the only things you’d be good at, except he doesn’t need a room and pay.”

Owen examined the creature closely. He knew enough about summoners to know that their creatures were often born of a problem or a need. Creating another being from nothing was intensely difficult; the only way to succeed was to pour an aspect of one’s self into it. The summons were supposed to do something that summoner couldn’t. They represented a strength to fill in a perceived weakness.

This summon was not built for heavy lifting. It was built for fighting. Maybe for killing.

“Guess we should give the people what they want,” Owen said, pointing to the other three Supers. “Why not have him give me a little tap?”

“I thought you’d never ask,” Hexcellent replied. “Big Henry, punch him with everything you’ve got.” This time she didn’t yell, she barely even raised her voice. Owen had just enough time to wonder if her summons even needed to be close enough to hear for her orders to work when Big Henry sprang at him.

This one didn't have as much grace as the other two, but he made up for it with a shocking amount of speed. He whirled forward, hooves nearly cracking the floor with each step, closing the gap between him and Owen in mere moments. The punch came at the end of the movement, part of the motion's flow that utilized the extra momentum. It was impressive, especially for a being that Owen suspected had never been trained. The black armored fist drove directly into his torso, right between his sternum and stomach. It had so much power that, even braced in an appropriate stance, Owen was still moved back several inches as the concrete under his feet crumbled against the indirect force.

"Better than I expected," Owen said, clearly unharmed or inconvenienced by the attack. He glanced up at Hexcellent, whose face had morphed from its usual antisocial glower into an expression of genuine shock. Given how strong this summon was, she'd likely thought it would at least do some damage to him. Owen didn't fault her for that belief. She hadn't been inside the Hero world; her sense of scale for what constituted strong didn't even have a ranking for someone like Titan.

"How durable is this one?" Owen asked, his question shaking her out of her surprised reverie.

"Damn near indestructible." Her jaw was setting, her eyes growing narrow. She was gearing up for round two, when she'd show that her summon was at least no less durable than he. If it could take his blow with the same lack of effect, it would prove they were on even footing. Owen, fortunately, knew better.

"Good to know," Owen said, taking a step back from the summon, which remained half-crouched to attack. "Luckily, since you don't have to use him to fight, we don't need to test that. Let's move on. Zone, how about you show me what you can do?"

Hexcellent stared at him for a few moments longer before dismissing Big Henry back to smoke. Owen was sure she wasn't happy with him at the moment, but that would have to wait. He needed to finish seeing everyone's skill set for now.

After that, he could work on making them better.

## 7.

Before either Zone or Owen could step forward, a bright red light flashed through the room, followed by a brief siren. That abated in moments, replaced by the calm voice of Mr. Greene.

“There is a fire two point five miles away from here. It’s an older building, and structural integrity is a concern. Firefighters are currently spread thin, so they’ve requested our help.”

“We’ll do it,” Galvanize yelled into the air. Owen presumed Greene could hear them, a suspicion confirmed moments later when the voice came back into the air.

“Understood. They’ll be expecting your arrival. Transport is in the basement when you’re ready.”

“You heard the man. Everyone, into your costumes and downstairs. If you take longer than five minutes, you’re getting left behind,” Galvanize commanded. His tone had seamlessly shifted from controlled but friendly to authoritative. Owen had no doubt he’d be abandoned if he dared go over the five-minute mark. Evidently the others believed Galvanize too, as they immediately dashed off toward the door, Zone peeling off part of his sweats before he’d even gotten clear of the room.

“Feeling nervous?” Galvanize asked, breaking into a light jog so as not to violate his own edict.

“Lil bit,” Owen admitted. “Been a long time.”

“You’ll be fine. Fires are where B.B. and Hexcellent really shine. Just follow orders and everyone will get home safe.”

“That would be a pleasant outcome,” Owen agreed. How nice these kids had it: when if they did their job right, no one died. In the Hero world, even if you did everything perfectly, sometimes success still meant blood on your hands.

\* \* \*

Titan nearly missed his debut that day, due to the mirror in Owen’s room. He’d tried on his old costume before leaving Colorado, of course, but

that had been a piecemeal ordeal, donning and checking each section separately so problems could be identified in turn. It wasn't until he was fully suited up, walking toward his door, that the figure in the mirror caught his attention and stopped him cold.

It had been over a decade since he'd seen this person looking back in a reflection. This was different than going to see Lenny; this was a man about to walk out into a world of danger. He wasn't just Owen Daniels wearing a costume. He was Titan, and the full of weight of that realization nearly sent him to the ground. So many memories, so many ordeals. So much loss. Part of him wanted to shrink back, to let Titan fall away in costumed pieces and turn back into Owen.

Instead, he reached up to the side of his mask and pressed a device in his ear, hidden by the red material covering his face. None of the others would have this accessory; it was only for Heroes. They'd made improvements to the ear pieces since he last suited up. This one was light and nestled in the crevice of his ear with total security, giving a sense that no sideways blow would knock it loose. The things had always been damned tough, but a good rocking could send them flying. Titan was unsurprised to find this flaw had been addressed.

"Titan, reporting in." His words echoed through the empty room.

"Dispatch recognizes Titan," said a soft voice in his ear. Somewhere in his stomach, a knot of worry loosened. Part of him worried Dispatch would have changed as well, but her voice was the same as always: strong, well-enunciated, and with a vaguely European accent. No one, at least no one Titan had ever talked to, knew Dispatch's real name, location, or even powers. She was just always there, no matter what time anyone plugged in. Always there, always the same.

"Titan, please respond," she repeated.

Owen realized he'd zoned out, listening to her voice but not her words. "Sorry, repeat the question."

"You are cleared for active Hero assignments and for monitoring of a Privately Employed Emergency Response Supers team. Which of these tasks are you signing in for?"

"I'm babysitting the corpies tonight," Owen replied, working very hard to keep the annoyance out of his voice. If he signed in for active Hero duty, it would mean she'd direct him to any calls for help that fit the bill.



Being on oversight duty meant he could use her if a situation arose, but she wouldn't try to assign any new tasks to him.

"Confirmed," Dispatch said. "Is your team responding to the fire on Forty-Third Street?" Since corpies and Heroes overlapped on rescue duties, Dispatch always knew who was going where.

"If that's about two miles from my current location, then yes." Owen broke his eyes away from the mirror and headed out his door. The earpiece wouldn't be bothered by anything like walking. He'd seen people easily hold conversations with Dispatch while flying at supersonic speeds.

"Confirmed. You are on note." Owen winced, involuntarily. "On note" meant he was officially working the incident, and any other Hero who wanted to check and see if it was handled could find out he was there. Being a working Hero made it pretty much impossible to keep a low profile.

"Thank you. Anything I should know going in?" Owen rounded the corner and stepped into the elevator at the end of the hall. The team had already informed him that the space below the lobby button would take him to a transport basement if pressed by someone with the right biometrics. A small push from his thumb and spot of clear metal suddenly lit up, sending him on a rapid journey downward.

"No documented Supers or Powered's in residence at the building. Cause of fire is undetermined, though given degree of neglect and decay in the neighborhood, natural causes are highly possible. Nothing in the reports so far suggests any variant-human activity."

"So if it is a Super, I'm going in blind," Owen muttered. He preferred to get at least a forewarning on these sorts of things.

"Again, nothing suggests--"

"I know, I know, sorry Dispatch. I'm just a little on edge," Owen told her.

"Ah yes, this is your first active assignment since renewing your license." Dispatch paused, an occurrence so rare it stood out like a curse in Owen's ear. "In that case, let me be the first to say welcome back. The world has missed you, Titan."

The elevator opened with a pneumatic whoosh, revealing a large black vehicle with a single open door. Owen moved toward it.

“Tell the world I’m on my way.”

## 8.

Their vehicle had a siren, which Owen found surprisingly delightful. In his Hero days, they'd had people with flight, teleportation, and other various means of covering distance, so the only time he'd heard sirens was from the police and emergency responders showing up in the aftermath. Sitting in the vehicle making the sound reminded him of his childhood, before his abilities manifested, when he would feel a thrill every time the firefighters or police officers would drive by.

Certainly, this team's transportation had far more advanced accoutrements than the siren. It was constructed out of an SUV; however, the whole thing had been heavily fortified, from the wheels to the antenna. Even with five people inside, one of whom was far from slender, the car had only dropped a few inches. Bright lights buzzed along the dashboard. Zone was fiddling with something where the passenger glove box should have been while Galvanize drove them quickly, but safely, through traffic. There was likely an electronics' store worth of useful gadgets and pricey doodads, all at their fingertips, but Owen was really only fond of the siren.

Everyone could see the telltale smoke billowing up from the fire a few blocks before they reached it. Had it been darker, Owen knew there would have been an orange glow cast against the clouds, visible for miles. Daytime stole much of the scenic drama away.

They came to a stop just outside a police barrier, Galvanize dashing out the door before the rest of them could even unbuckle their seatbelts.

"He has to go talk to the cops and firemen," Hexcellent said, answering a question that Owen would have been tactful enough not to ask. "Unlike Heroes, we can't just gallivant in wherever we want. We have to respect the chain of authority." She'd changed into her costume, a black number with lots of zippers, buckles, and torn fishnets. Several logos, apparently for makeup companies, dotted her outfit; one for a clothing store named Fiery Discussion was featured no fewer than four times.

"To be fair, it's also a good practice because they can tell us where our help is needed most," Zone added. His costume was comprised of a skintight material across his torso that was see-through everywhere a logo wasn't present. It seemed he was heavily sponsored by skateboard companies,

a few football franchises, and one very enthusiastic energy drink. The latter logo, for a brand called Punch Juice, took up almost the entirety of his back.

“He’s right,” Owen agreed. “When we can, Heroes talk to uniforms, too. It’s smart to get all the information you can.”

Zone gave a nod, but pointedly avoided making eye contact with Owen, despite the older man’s agreement. This, it seemed, was going to be the least cordial of his working relationships. He idly wondered if Zone was a fundamentalist, a bigot, or just didn’t care for having a washed-up Hero on his team. It didn’t really matter; as long as the young man could stay polite, he was free to dislike Owen all he wanted.

“We should catch up,” Bubble Bubble advised them. Her costume was barely a costume at all, more like an experimental outfit from a high-end designer. It was white and green, which went well with the emerald contacts she’d slipped over her naturally brown eyes, and hugged her body in a way that spoke to the figure beneath without going so far as to divulge secrets. Even the logos she wore seemed a bit more tasteful than the others’, colors downplayed so they didn’t clash with her ensemble. Bubble Bubble was sponsored by makeup companies, as well as skin management creams, and a name Owen fleetingly recognized as someone who made designer handbags.

Corpies didn’t need costumes or masks, of course, since they didn’t undertake activities that earned them enemies. Heroes wore the capes and cowls by tradition as well as necessity: when one’s job required capturing or killing powerful people who often have powerful friends, it’s essential for them not to know where one hung their hat. Corpies were effectively specialized rescue services, like EMT or firefighters. They weren’t making anyone mad, so it was assumed by most, Owen included, that they wore the costumes in a vain attempt to seem more like the Heroes they weren’t. He kept those thoughts to himself as they exited the car and headed toward Galvanize. It was a free country, and they had as much right to wear costumes as they did to wear t-shirts or jeans.

Their leader met them a few feet from the building, his outfit’s cape flapping slightly in the breeze. Galvanize wore a costume closest to the style of real Heroes: a navy and white ensemble with cuffed gloves, calf-high boots, and even an emblazoned cape. He was sponsored by Punch Juice as well, along with several protein and nutritional supplement companies. The enthusiastic young man wore a serious expression, exactly what one should look like when dealing with a dangerous situation. Owen knew the pictures of

him would look great, which he took to be the point.

“All right, team. I just spoke with the firemen, and this place is very unstable. They believe they’ve gotten everyone out from the bottom floors, but the top ones have proven treacherous to explore. We need to search for any survivors. Hexcellent, get Impers up to the top floor immediately and have him let us know if he finds anyone. Zone, I want you to start on the floor below. Bubble Bubble, that means he needs a way up. Titan, you and I will make our way from the ground. Hexcellent and B.B. will stay out here to evacuate anyone from the higher floors with Big Henry and energy spheres. Be quick, be adaptable, and make sure you don’t get in the way of the firemen’s way. Any questions?”

“Do they know what started the fire?” Zone asked.

“Nothing conclusive. It’s an old building, lots of smokers and ancient wiring,” Galvanize replied. “If that’s it, let’s go!”

Galvanize had no sooner yelled the last part than everyone sprang into action. Hexcellent summoned Impers in a cloud of smoke and had him leap into the air, heading for the top floor. Galvanize took off toward the entrance, pausing only to throw a small black mask on over his mouth and nose. Owen was a few steps behind, lagging a bit out of curiosity. Bubble Bubble had been told to give Zone a way up to the second highest floor. Given what Owen knew of their powers, he was wondering how they were going to pull that off.

The spectacle did not disappoint. Zone took off running, aiming himself at the side of the building. In a smooth, fluid motion he leapt from the ground, foot catching a brick window sill that he used for a second leap. Another jump off the top of the window’s outcropping brought him a few feet higher, but with it he was out of usable footholds until the next window. When Zone’s sneakers met the flat, brick wall, he pushed backward instead of up, executing a perfect backflip that sent him twirling through the air. Instead of plummeting to the ground, as one would have expected, he momentarily landed on the energy sphere Bubble Bubble had placed directly under him. Launching himself off of it, Zone’s nimble feet made it to the next window sill and the dance began all over again. It was difficult, dangerous, and stupidly risky.

But it was impressive. Owen had to give them that.



## 9.

The wave of heat that washed over Owen was oppressive, stifling, and strangely familiar. It had been well past a decade since he plunged into a wild inferno; he found the experience a touch nostalgic.

The bottom floor of the building was almost entirely engulfed in flames to some degree, thick, dark smoke pouring out and limiting visibility. From what he could see, the situation looked grim. Despite the brick exteriors, almost the entire inside was made of wood, wood that was rapidly turning to ash. At the rate the fire was spreading, it was a matter of when, not if, the entire structure was going to come crashing down. By his estimates, they had maybe twenty minutes left, and that was only thanks to the incredible efforts of the firefighters to control the flames.

“Come on,” Galvanize urged, his voice coming through the communicator in Owen’s left ear. Right ear was always reserved for Dispatch, but he needed to be able to talk with his team as well. Their earbuds weren’t quite as good as the Hero-issued ones; however, they weren’t as far behind the curve as he might have guessed they’d be.

Owen followed his leader, taking careful steps. The floor appeared solid enough, but the stairs were a source of concern for him. They weren’t blazing in earnest yet, so thankfully their structural integrity was enough to hold his weight as he ascended to the second floor. Still, Owen continued being watchful of his movements. Him falling through a few burning floors wouldn’t injure him in the slightest, but it would definitely hasten this building’s destruction.

The first and second floors were clear of everyone save for emergency responders, and it was obvious they were going to have to pull out soon. The building was eight stories tall, so that meant they likely had at least two more levels to go before they met up with Zone and Impers, assuming neither team had to stop and facilitate any rescues. He hoped they would find the whole place properly evacuated. Getting someone out of the middle floors might be tricky.

“Does the heat bother you?” The question came so suddenly that Owen nearly twitched in surprise, a move that easily could have crushed the smoldering wood beneath his feet. Luckily, his entire career of experience

hadn't quite deserted him, so he managed to keep control.

"No, not really," he replied. "I'm a little surprised at how well you're taking it, though."

"I did mention I was a bit hardier than normal," Galvanize replied. "Besides, the costume does a lot of the work. It's specially built for extreme temperatures in either direction, along with a fair bit of armoring in the more vulnerable spots, just in case I get hit by debris or something. Pair it with the breather mask, which keeps me from getting carbon monoxide poisoning, and it's a handy ensemble."

"Pretty snazzy," Owen said, dating himself unapologetically with his word choice.

"One of the perks of working for the big guys. When I started out all I got was a t-shirt with a logo on it. This is much safer."

Galvanize's word choice struck Owen as intriguing. He'd have expected the glorified model to use words like "nicer," "cleaner," "more appealing," or even "sexier." "Safer" implied that his first concern was for the job the uniform denoted, not how it made him look. Owen had known Heroes who wouldn't have said safer. Again he felt his respect for the wavy-haired young man raise a few degrees. Even if he was only playing a part, he played it exceptionally well.

It was on the third floor that their streak of finding everyone safely removed came to a halt. They'd just come off the stairs when Owen heard muffled screaming coming from a few apartments away. His hearing was good—above human grade but not so impressive that it would count as an ability on its own—so he could also make out sounds of someone scuffling about.

"We've got people," he declared, alerting Galvanize while taking two careful, but sizable, steps toward the apartment that the noise was coming from. A single attempt on the doorknob told him it was locked, and he could see keyholes for three deadbolts. He reared back his hefty fist and prepared to turn the door into splinters.

"Titan, hold!" Galvanize's order was curt and quick, spoken with the sort of veteran authority that reminded Owen of his intern days. "Time is short, but we don't know where they are behind that door. You punching it could seriously injure someone."



“Got a better idea?”

“Yes, actually. You’re incredibly strong, so just stick a finger through the door and run it down past where the knob and deadbolts are. That should let us in without sending chunks flying through the home.”

Owen bit back a terse remark and did as he was told. It was easy, like sticking a finger into pudding. The deadbolts put up a valiant effort to stop his index finger, but they may as well have tried to reason with a thunderstorm. In less than half a minute the locks were removed. Galvanize moved forward, pushing the door open and stepping into the apartment’s living room.

The two men had both been in rescue situations before, and this was not the first fire for either, so they’d had certain expectations of what to find behind the door. A huddled, scared group of people awaiting rescue, a panicked cluster that would race forward and possibly knock their rescuers down, or even the worst case scenario: one or more bodies that had already been claimed by smoke inhalation. This was none of those situations. Not even close.

A group of four adults were racing about, filling buckets from the sink and, judging by sound, the tub, emptying them on to a person in the center of the room, then repeating the process. This person in the center was young, roughly seven to nine if Owen had to guess, and sitting in a metal washtub that was glowing from the heat. This heat wasn’t from the fire that was engulfing the building; it came directly from the source.

This young person, a girl, Owen realized as he noticed her hair and facial features, was the one who had released the muffled screams. They didn’t seem to be ones of pain; that would have been impossible to bite back. No, these screams were likely of fear, or guilt, some mixture containing elements of the two. She was clearly terrified, and Owen didn’t blame her one bit.

Because, in addition to sitting, crying, and screaming softly, the young girl was also engulfed in fire. Her whole body rippled with flame, cascading off and flowing to the world around her.

“Shit,” Galvanize said, taking a step back. “We’ve got a Super.”

## 10.

Owen didn't fault Galvanize for assuming they were dealing with a Super. He was in a dangerous situation, and a Super willfully causing fires would be his worst case scenario. It meant he had to run like hell and leave these people behind, because he wasn't cleared to stop a fire-coated arsonist. It was a reasonable leap to make, but it was wrong.

There were things he recognized, as a former Hero, and as a father, that told him something was off. The blackened spots on the metal tub showed it had been used for similar purposes before. The people, probably her family, were scared and frantic but not lost in terror, and that meant this was something they'd come to terms with. The way the girl was sobbing and trying to bite back her fear spoke volumes of how much she hated what was happening to her. Above all was the efficiency of the system they were using to douse her. This had been planned, worked on, and drilled. They knew she might start burning, and they had a method in place to deal with it.

"She's not a Super," Owen said, correcting his team leader. "She's a Powered. She can't control it."

"You can't. . ." Galvanize's words trailed off as his brain finally snapped to the context clues Owen had already seen. Fear had made him momentarily slow, not stupid. "Crud, I think you might be right."

"I am right," Owen stepped forward, his large body's movement finally seeming to snap the people in the apartment to awareness of the costumed men's presence. One of the older men lowered his bucket and raced over to Owen.

"No. . . go. . . Go away!" His voice was heavy with a Hispanic accent, and his stilted way of speaking made it clear he was still learning English. Once upon a time Owen could have faked his way through some basic phrases, but Spanish was a skill he'd long ago let rust to oblivion on his mental shelf.

Galvanize, thankfully, had not been so lax in his language exercises. He hurried over immediately, snapping into a quick, fluent conversation with the older man. Owen was impressed; the kid even rolled his *r*'s, a trick Owen had never managed to get down.

“I’m hitting a wall,” Galvanize told him after a few moments of conversation. “They understand that the building is on fire, but they’re refusing to leave. They seem to think we’re here to take the girl away.” He shot Owen a confused expression, visible even through the mask and breather apparatus on his face. “Any insight you want to offer?”

“Mirror Fog really did keep you kids away from other Supers, didn’t he?” Titan gave a small shake of his head. “Powered with abilities that are a severe danger to others, ones like hers, are often put in ‘protective custody’ until they find a way to let them safely interact with society. Usually some tech-genius can slap a suit or something on them, but there’s always rumors of people never being heard from again.” Owen pointedly refrained from commenting on his own suspicions of the validity regarding those rumors. There were more important things at the moment.

“I can see how he’d be worried about that,” Galvanize said, sparing a moment to glance at the growing amount of fire filling the building. “But we need to get them out. I’m going to have to ask you to pick them up and remove them forcefully.”

“You open to a suggestion?”

“I’ll hear it out,” Galvanize assured him.

“They’re here to protect the girl. If I take her out, they’ll follow on their own. Faster and safer,” Owen pointed out.

“True but. . . well, I guess you’re allowed to deal with her. But be gentle: Powered or not, she’s still a person.”

In that moment, Owen’s grudging respect for the young man leading this team of corporate shills metamorphosed into genuine affection. Job be damned, he liked this kid.

“Don’t worry,” Owen assured him, stepping past the older man still jabbering in a language he couldn’t understand. Dimly, he felt a pair of hands grip his bicep, some poorly thought out attempt at stopping him. His assailant, like countless others who’d tried such things before, was in for disappointment.

Owen continued forward, kneeling down next the metal tub and staring at the girl in the face. He smiled at her, his big, wide, corny grin that had endeared him to the hearts of the public so many years ago. It seemed he still had a bit of his old charming magic left, because the girl stopped crying

long enough to turn and look at him.

“Are you okay?” His voice was calm and gentle, ignoring the urgency of the situation around him.

“No,” she said, her words high-pitched, hoarse, and heartbreaking. “I can’t stop this time. I keep trying and it won’t stop.”

“Don’t worry,” Owen assured her. “I’ll get you out of here. We’ll go out to your apartment’s pool and help you cool down. Does that sound okay?”

She shook her head fiercely. “I can’t leave. I can’t get up. I’ll burn people. I’ve burned Papa and Mama and my sister and our house. . . I burn everything.”

With great care, Owen reached out his hand and brought it down on top of her head, momentarily smothering out the flames before they regrouped and dashed across his skin. The girl tried to pull away, but he held fast, holding his hand there long enough to send the message. Then, he pulled it away and held his fingers in front of her face.

“You can’t burn me. I’m special, like you. No matter how scared you get, no matter how hot you get, you can’t hurt me. I promise.”

Her eyes grew wide (an unsettling sight since they were still coated in flames) as she stared at his unmarred skin. Not even the hair from the back of his knuckles had been singed. She reached out and grasped his fingers with hers, ever so carefully, and watched in amazement as the fire coating her failed to scorch him in the slightest.

“Who are you?”

“My name is Titan. What’s yours?”

“Alexandria.”

“Well, Alexandria, how about that swim?”

She nodded, and he reached over, delicately scooping her out of her metal washtub and pulling her against his chest. His uniform crackled and wrinkled as she came into the contact with it, but his words held true as the fire proved unable to burn him.

“Ready when you are,” Titan told Galvanize, who gave a quick nod and hurriedly escorted the rest of the apartment’s occupants to the stairs. Titan followed, even more careful with his steps than before.



## 11.

It took a good ten minutes of submersion in the apartment complex's pool, now partially filled with ash, before Alexandria's cloak of flames started to dissipate. Titan spent that time talking with her, asking her about life and school, pretending he wasn't gently holding her face above water while the rest of her body sent steam billowing into the late-morning air. Before taking her out of the building, he'd wrapped her in his fire-resistant over-shirt, illustrating one of the many reasons that Heroes always dressed in layers. It had held up well, which was a stroke of good fortune because he was relatively certain she'd have torched through anything else he could have used.

Having fathered Powered, Titan was more familiar with their condition than most. Their abilities were triggered involuntarily. Sometimes this response was purely physical, like a nervous tic. Sometimes it happened from other stimuli, like sneezing. And for many, their ability was tied to their emotions. So while the water was keeping Alexandria from burning anything else, Titan had a firm suspicion that it was the act of calming her down that finally banished the flames.

The rest of the team had finished checking the building and reported there were no more people left inside. Only Alexandria's family had stayed behind, too scared to move her and perhaps set something else aflame. With the coast clear, the firefighters had pulled out and focused on getting the blaze under control. Galvanize, Hexcellent, Bubble Bubble, and Zone had all gathered out in front of the smoking building to catch the eye of various reporters and news crews that were gathering on the scene. Technically, Titan should be with them, but he felt he was doing better work standing waist deep in dirty water, getting a little girl down from her emotional rollercoaster.

"Titan, the Powered girl's transport is en route. Estimate arrival in five point two minutes." Dispatch's voice hummed in his ear, nearly startling him. He'd forgotten about the earpiece already. It would take some time for the Hero habits to kick back in. At least he'd remembered to call the incident in. A person with her ability and no control needed some serious help.

"Understood." Titan tapped the side of his mask covering his ear as Alexandria looked on curiously. He stuck out his thumb and pinky, making an "I'm on the phone" gesture to explain his apparent discussion with no one.

“The secondary transport as well?”

“Yes, another car for the girl’s family is paired with the one for her. They will not be able to ride in the same vehicle.”

Titan smiled down at the girl, but inwardly winced. If he threw her into a mysterious van without so much as a friendly face, it was highly likely she would flare up again. The team getting her would have things to control her fire, but it wouldn’t be a great first impression.

“I can accompany. There shouldn’t be any danger for me.”

“It was never an issue of danger. We have equipment to completely neutralize a fire-conjurer of the level you described; however, that equipment occupies a large amount of space. We cannot fit anyone in the van aside from the driver and the Powered.”

Damn, there went that idea. If a normal person couldn’t fit, then Titan had no chance of squeezing in. He was still trying to think of another way to help when Dispatch's voice grabbed his attention again.

“Titan, another Hero has flagged your location as a destination. Gale is currently en route.”

“Make that ‘arrived.’”

The new voice came from a source high above the pool: a woman floating forty feet in the air. She wore a green and black outfit: standard pants and top paired with a matching ankle-length coat. It fluttered out behind her, billowing in the breeze as she began to descend.

She was halfway down when Titan realized there was no breeze. That probably meant air-elementalist, and if she had enough oomph to fly herself without riding on something as ostentatious as a hurricane, then she must be a pretty good one. Her brunette hair flitted about as she descended, coming to rest a few inches below her shoulders when she finally landed.

“Gale, I presume?”

The woman, Gale, nodded, and then flashed a warm smile at Alexandria. She turned her attention back to the man in the soot-covered outfit a moment later. “And you’re Titan, or so I’m told.”

“That I am.”

“From what I heard, Titan left the business years ago. So that leaves

me with a question: original or legacy?” Her tone was cheerful, and the smile she’d shown Alexandria had only faded a bit, yet Titan could still sense the tension in her body as she quizzed him. He didn’t blame her; the return of someone as legendarily infamous as himself was bound to stir up a lot of something. Maybe it would be bad, maybe it would be good, but it would be something.

“Original,” Titan replied. “Just reinstated, actually. You caught me on my first job.”

“A burning building? Interesting choice for a strongman.”

“Long story,” Titan said with a sigh.

“Are you really Gale?” This question came from neither of the registered Heroes, but rather from the small girl who had finally stopped burning a few minutes prior. Both adults looked at her, realizing they had something more important on their hands than a pissing contest.

“I really am,” Gale told her. She took a step off the edge of the concrete and began to hover over the water, making small ripples below her feet as she glided across the water’s surface. “See? I can fly and everything.”

Seeing her interact kindly with Alexandria, it struck Titan that Gale was quite pretty, a fact that was evident even through the mask that concealed all save for her eyes, a bit of nose, and from the mouth downward. Dark skin, full lips, and likely a fit body beneath all the armored clothing she wore. If his inclinations had lain in that direction, he’d have been a bit tempted to ask for her number.

“You came to speak at our school last year,” Alexandria said. “You talked about how being a Hero meant making good choices, even for young people like us.”

“And I meant every word,” Gale assured her.

Alexandria nodded, even though nothing had been asked of her. The girl was clearly star-struck. Titan would have bet dollars to donuts that somewhere in the cinders of her now-charred room were the remains of a Gale poster. That thought, sad as it was, gave him an idea.

“Gale, maybe you can help me—us—out,” he said carefully. “I’ve got friends who are coming to take Alexandria and her family somewhere secure, where she won’t have to worry about setting things on fire. Unfortunately, her



car will be too small for anyone else to ride with her, but I want her to know she's still got people watching over her. Are you free to fly alongside her car and make sure she arrives safely?"

"Of course I can," Gale said, giving the young girl another comforting smile. "That works out well, actually. I wanted to see if you had some free time later on to chat, so now we can meet up after and I can assure you everything went fine."

Titan had known he was handing out a favor by asking her to do escort duty, but he hadn't expected her to cash it in immediately. Clearly she wanted to know about his return as soon as possible. From the way Alexandria had recognized her and her skill at diplomacy, it seemed a fair guess that she was one of the better known Heroes in the city, which meant she likely also belonged to one of the top teams. He'd hoped to avoid getting too mixed up in the Hero world before he settled in here, but it looked like that wasn't going to happen.

Oh well. At least he was going to get something out of it.

"Sounds like a great idea," Titan agreed.

## 12.

“Nice job.”

Mr. Greene was the first thing the team saw when they stepped through the door of their base; he stood between the living room and the kitchen, wearing an almost aggressively neutral expression.

“Thank you, sir,” Galvanize responded immediately. “We were thankful to get everyone out with no injuries or deaths. It was a good day.”

“Very good,” Mr. Greene amended. “The firefighters actually went on record thanking you for your help, the footage of Zone leaping into the building is being picked up by a station running the story, and the post-rescue photos came out looking quite striking.”

Owen wondered how this man knew so much about pictures he hadn’t taken and stations he didn’t run, then let the curiosity slide away. This place had a lot of money, and Owen had been around more than long enough to know that with the right amount of cash, there was almost nothing one couldn’t access.

“Unfortunately, our newest team member wasn’t present in any of the group photos.” Mr. Greene’s face was still neutral, his tone still even, yet one could feel the disapproval radiating off of him. “Titan, you understand that as Hero Liaison to this team you’re expected to appear alongside them, don’t you?”

“I know what I signed up for, and I’ve got no issue with that, when time permits. My priority was taking care of a little girl who couldn’t stop herself from radiating fire. Once she was safe, I went to join in the photo-shoot, but it had already wrapped up.”

“A girl radiating fire? Galvanize, please explain,” Mr. Greene said.

“There was a Powered in the building. She seemed to be cloaked in flames and was unable to extinguish herself. Titan secured her, calmed her down, and arranged for her to be transported somewhere safe where she wouldn’t present a danger to herself or others. He prioritized it as higher importance than dealing with the media, and I agreed. Left unattended, she could have injured someone or started a new blaze.”

Owen felt a spark of surprise at Galvanize's words. That was only somewhat how it had happened; in truth, he'd just taken the girl down and Galvanize hadn't stopped him, but this made it sound like the actions of Titan had been done at Galvanize's orders. The kid was putting himself on the chopping block instead of Owen.

Mr. Greene stared at the two men for a long moment. "And why couldn't Hexcellent have had one of her demons restrain the child? They are also fireproof, as well as less necessary to be seen on camera."

"The fire was coming from fear," Owen said, not about to let Galvanize try and absorb anymore blame. "Powereds' abilities often tie to their emotions. She was scared because she lost control and that fear fed her ability, causing a chain reaction that almost torched a whole building. Hexcellent's demons aren't what anyone would call child-friendly, so I seemed like a smarter pick for calming her down."

Mr. Greene remained silent for a few seconds then seemed to relax.

"Very well. Our first job is to provide emergency services, and it appears your choices were made with the public's safety in mind, so missing a photo-op is an acceptable loss. Just make sure everyone, Titan included, writes up their standard post-response report. Every detail, every action, every name of every person encountered. There were no injuries today, but we all know that doesn't preclude reports surfacing later. Good day."

Mr. Greene strolled out of the room, eyes staring straight ahead as he headed down the hall.

"What's this about reports now?" Owen looked around, finding that the rest of the team didn't seem to share his confusion.

"Post-response reports," Galvanize told him. "PEERS are big targets for the occasional lawsuit. We'll have people we pull out of cars claim we caused exacerbations to their injuries, or that our presence made things worse, stuff like that. The company can usually beat them with telepaths, but those can get muddy, legally speaking, so one of the ways they combat it is to have us document everything we did. A lot of lawsuits have fallen apart when the person's story didn't match up at all to what we recorded."

"Sounds like a massive pain in the ass," Owen said. "No one mentioned paperwork."

"Why don't you blow it off then, like you did doing camera work?"

Zone had been silent for most of the trip back, but it was immediately clear that it hadn't been because he had nothing to say. "Just let Galvanize stand in for you again. God forbid the legendary Hero cop up to his own fuck-ups."

"Zone, that's enough," Galvanize snapped.

"No, let him go." Owen patted Galvanize's shoulder then turned to face Zone. Looking the younger man in eye required Owen to tilt his head at a noticeable incline. "He's been biting back his tongue since I got here; that shit isn't healthy. Come on, kid, if you've got something to say then say it."

"Gladly! I think it was a mistake to bring you on. Mirror Fog was a Hero, but he wasn't like you. He was a decent guy, humble, never looking down on us. But you? From the minute you stepped in here you've acted like Babe Ruth sitting at a tee-ball game. Missing the photo-op is just one more example of the real problem: you think you're better than us. You didn't want to be seen with us. And while I'm used to that from Heroes, to see it from you just chaps my ass, because you are in no *fucking* way better than us. "

Zone's face was red, a vein bulging near the top of his forehead. He looked half-ready to swing; likely the only thing holding him back was the knowledge that it would injure his hand if he struck Titan's legendarily tough body. Owen leaned closer, until he was less than a foot from the fuming man's face.

"And what, pray tell, makes me so much worse than the other Heroes?"

"Because you're a goddamned coward." Zone spun around and stormed out of the living room, off toward the gym.

Owen stood there, frozen in place. He'd expected any number of things to come out of Zone's mouth: bigotry, arrogance, outright hate, but he hadn't been braced for that little bastard to cut to the quick of him.

Coward. That was what he'd called himself countless times over his years in exile. He'd tormented himself with that word for so long, but it had been a private pain. It had genuinely never occurred to him that others would see his failings all on their own.

"Ignore Zone; he's got a short fuse and an ego bigger than he needs," Galvanize said. "He'll calm down once I explain that you skipping the photos wasn't a personal slight."

“It’s fine,” Owen said at last. He looked over; it hadn’t escaped his notice that while Galvanize was keeping the peace, Hexcellent and Bubble Bubble had both remained silent after Zone’s rant. One look at their faces told him why: they agreed with their teammate. Maybe not about him being worse than other Heroes, but certainly about him thinking he was too good for them.

And they weren’t really wrong, were they? He had been thinking that way, ever since Lenny handed him their folder.

“I promise, we’ll get things smoothed out-”

“Just show me where to get one of those report things,” Owen said, and Galvanize went quiet. “Please. I want to get it done with.” As much as he would have liked to sink into a funk over his lifetime of failings, Owen needed to knock the paperwork out as soon as possible.

Little as he felt like going, he still had to meet with Gale.

## 13.

There were all sorts of Hero-themed bars and restaurants: Supper with Supers, Capes & Cocktails, and Planet Hero were only some of the more nationally franchised ones. For the most part they were horrendously tacky affairs, with staff wearing costumes and walls decorated in art featuring Heroes or sometimes vintage Hero memorabilia.

In larger cities, Heroes would frequent these establishments in costume, stopping in to have a quick beer or bite then sign autographs for the adoring fans. Such appearances were, of course, purchased by the respective establishment and carefully scheduled. They wanted patrons to think that any trip could lead to meeting a real-life Hero in the flesh.

Off-duty Heroes, or ones not contractually obligated to show up, avoided those places like they'd seen the kitchen. A real Hero bar was one that catered to them when the capes were off. This type of bar masqueraded as unassuming watering holes, a place akin to a dive without the rustic charm. There was, of course, no way to turn away non-Heroes without advertising what clientele they actually catered to. Instead, the staff made sure regular people didn't want to stay. Horrid service, flat beer at room temperature, and food that would turn a garbage disposal's stomach ensured that if you weren't supposed to be at a Hero bar, it wasn't a place you felt inclined to linger.

Owen felt the assessing stares as he stepped through the door of Brin's Gate, a small bar twenty minutes' jog from base. He was dressed in street clothes, as was everyone else here. Stepping into a place like this wearing a costume would have defeated the whole point. The staff, sizing him up from afar, could clearly see he was big. But "big" might only mean he was a Super, not a Hero, and even that required some assumptions. He'd probably be stuck getting treated like a mundane until Gale arrived and vouched for him.

"Hey, over here!" A breeze hit his left ear and Owen turned to find Gale standing up at a booth and waving him over. He noticed the staff relax, accepting him as a proper client. It usually took more than a wave to do that. Either this place had lax standards or Gale had more clout than Owen realized.

He lumbered across the room and slid onto the bench that awaited him. Instead of the usual groans and creaks he was accustomed to from

furniture, the seat held firm. That was one thing about Hero bars: they either started out with reinforced furniture or very quickly learned to get some.

Gale was dressed in slacks and a blouse, the sort of outfit that said she might have just gotten off work or might be heading out for a proper dinner after her drink. In front of her was a cocktail, halfway watered down by the melted ice.

“Been waiting long?”

“I had another meeting here earlier, so I just hung around for this one,” Gale replied. “I appreciate you being prompt.”

“Course. We all have our schedules to keep.”

The waitress came by, and Owen ordered a local beer. Once she left, he turned the conversation toward the most important subject, so far as he was concerned. “Everything go okay with Alexandria?”

“No issues. She made it to the facility without so much as a flare-up. I think it helped that she was a little star-struck.” Gale was keeping a neutral face while she examined Owen with attentive eyes. “I’m surprised you care so much about one Powered girl.”

“First job back. Haven’t had time to get jaded again. . . yet.” Owen’s beer arrived and he took a long draw from it. Dark, yeasty, and potent; he’d have to find out the name of the brewery so he could try more of their wares.

“About that. I was wondering what made you decide to leave retirement. And why you picked Brewster, Illinois, to reappear in, of all places. We’re a decent-sized city, but we’re no New York or Los Angeles.”

“I left retirement because I wanted to start doing some good again,” Owen said. “As for why I came here. . . my agent had set up shop locally, and this is where I got a job.”

“You’re on a team?”

“I’m. . .” The urge to lie, or at least tell half-truths, was almost overpowering. But Zone’s words were still ringing in Owen’s ears. He thought he was better than them, and what right did he have? Those kids didn’t have his power or training, yet they were still doing the best they could to help people. Meanwhile, he’d taken all his abilities and holed up in Colorado. Like a coward.

“I’m working as a Hero Liaison for a team of Privately Employed Emergency Response Supers. I’m also going to do a little Hero work when time permits, but they’re my main job.”

Gale stared at him then let out a short, sharp, laugh. “You expect me to believe that Titan, *the* Titan, finally came out of hiding just to lead a bunch of corpies? I’m not an idiot.”

“No, you’re the leader of Elemental Fury, one of the most well-known teams in Brewster. It’s been in existence for over two decades and you’re the fourth leader they’ve had, presiding for the last three years. Your team is efficient, skilled, and great at minimizing collateral damage, which is probably part of why you’re so liked by the citizens. It also means you’re on top, which makes you a target for criminals and Heroes more concerned with image than the job. You think I’m the latter.” Owen had done more than just paperwork in his time before the meeting; he’d also pulled up some background information on Gale. Knowledge was usually more useful than muscle, in his experience.

“Titan was quite a media juggernaut in his day. I find it hard to believe you plan on lying low. Seems like you might want to be the new big dog in town, and the only way someone with your rep could do that would be to make us look bad.”

“I’m not here for the media, and I’m sure as shit not a gunner who is going to sabotage your PR. Those guys don’t last as long as I did before I quit, and you know that.”

“I’m not sure what I know when it comes to you,” Gale said. “Nearly every piece of information I have on you is from hearsay and propaganda. The one thing I do know is that you’re powerful and experienced, which makes you dangerous.”

“Only if I come with ill intentions, which I don’t.”

“Why should I believe that? You come here and feed me a story about baby-sitting corpies, giving me nothing to go on. I’m not trying to be a bitch, Titan, but this is my city. I was born here, I grew up here, and I lay my life on the line every day to keep it safe. Glory-seekers are a real danger; they take stupid risks that get people killed. For someone on your scale of power, that could be a whole lot of people.”

“Gale, you can either trust me or not. What you can’t do is stop me.” Owen meant it in a general sense, but he saw her tense. She probably had a



hurricane ready to go the moment he made a sudden move. “I mean that in a technical way. I’ve got my certification and my license. Until I do something worthy of bringing before the DVA, I’m free to fulfill my Hero duties as I see fit.”

“I can make it hard on you.”

“That just gets us into a stupid feud, and I don’t need that kind of headache,” Owen replied. “Here’s what I’d suggest instead: watch me. Let my actions tell you if I’m here to hunt glory or here to help. If I fuck up, then you’ve got something to bring before the DVA. If not, well, maybe along the way you’ll realize I’m telling the truth.”

“You know damned well I was going to put surveillance on you anyway.” Gale gulped down the last of her drink, half-melted ice cubes and all.

“It might have occurred to me.” Owen gave a lopsided grin and finished his own drink.

“All right. I’ll back off for now, on one condition.”

“Let’s hear it.”

“I want you to come by my base for an ability assessment,” Gale replied. “I’ll feel more comfortable once I know what you can do, and it’ll be interesting to see how my team stacks up against a legend.”

“I’d have to schedule it around my own team. I wasn’t kidding about them being my main priority.”

“Understood. We’ll shake our schedules and make something work. Bring them along if you like. Might be a thrill for them to see what a real Hero team looks like.”

For a reason Owen couldn’t yet define, that comment rankled him.

“I’ll find a time. Hate to tell you this, though, but you were wrong about one thing.”

“What’s that?” Gale asked.

“Once you’ve seen what I can do, comfortable is the last thing you’ll be feeling.”

## 14.

The powerful knocking on his door roused Lenny from a pleasant dream. In it, he'd been just about to sign three coordinated Hero teams under a group contract, with a percentage that was so high he'd have never allowed himself to indulge it in real life. The caped leader had been putting his signature on the contract when he jerked, slamming his knee into the desk. Then he did it again, and again, over and over until Lenny tore free of his dream world and realized someone very strong was knocking on his door.

It took him exactly one guess to figure out who'd come a-calling. Truthfully, he'd expected this visit to come earlier.

"Gimme a damn minute!" Lenny rolled out of bed and put on his orthopedic slippers. Other men might have been embarrassed to greet a visitor comparable to the gods while wearing gray house-shoes. Other men lacked the brass-balled confidence of Lenny.

He trudged through his home, a one-bedroom apartment next door to his office, heading toward the door. Lenny could certainly afford better. One didn't get to be as renowned as he was without squirreling away a good nest egg, after all. But that was for when he retired. Lenny lived and breathed the job; you had to if you wanted to be good at it. The closest thing he'd had to a vacation in the last decade was when he went to the coast to bail one of his clients out of a drunken indecent exposure charge.

The knocking ceased as Lenny pulled open the door, revealing the mountainous form of Owen holding a twelve-pack.

"Can I come in?"

"Wipe your feet." Lenny trudged back in, heading for the kitchen. He heard the door close behind him as he reached into the fridge and pulled out one of the frozen coffee drinks his doctor said was bad for his stomach lining. "Tough shit, Doc," he muttered as he downed the frosty concoction. That done, Lenny walked back into the living room.

"So, I take it things are bad." He'd known Owen long enough to skip the preamble. The big lug was bothered about something, and Lenny was the only person he felt he could talk to. That in itself pretty much spoke to the problem: he wasn't getting on well with his new team, else he'd have been

talking to them.

“They’re not great.” Owen cracked open a beer and took a lengthy sip. His body had long ago lost the ability to be affected by alcohol; that didn’t mean he didn’t find enjoyment in the flavor, though. “Looks like I’ve alienated my team by acting like I’m better than them, one member seems to have hated me before I walked in the door, and I managed to catch the eye of Elemental Fury’s leader, Gale. She seems to think I’m here to cause waves and might just make it her goal to be a pain in my ass.”

“That is pretty damned not great,” Lenny agreed. He reached over and pulled a beer free from the case. If the man was going to barge into his home at almost midnight, the least he could do was share his drinks. “Not great, but not unmanageable either. Gale is a righteous bitch if she suspects someone of making trouble; however, she’s one of the best people to have in your corner if she trusts you.”

“One of your clients?”

“No, though I manage Birdsman and Granite, two people on her team. I’m involved enough to get a sense of her. Lady’s got a lot of pressure on her to perform, and Brewster has been growing more active with criminal Supers over the last few years. Once she sees you’re genuinely trying to help, she’ll back off. Until then, just keep your temper in check and try to keep the dick-measuring to a minimum.”

“Might be tough; she invited me over to do an ability assessment.”

Lenny held in the exasperated sigh that might have escaped from an individual less tenured in his role. Ability assessments were officially used by Heroes when they were looking to work with someone and needed to know exactly what that person was capable of. Unofficially, they were a great way to put rookies in their place or settle grudges of which Super was more powerful. Heroes were good folk, but that much power and training definitely resulted in equally superhuman egos.

“Did you agree?”

“Sort of. I said I would do it when schedules aligned, so I bought some time at least.” Owen gave a wide-shouldered shrug.

“It’ll have to be enough. Let me try and finagle a few things. Until you hear from me, focus on your real problem: the team.”

“That’s the one I’m most clueless about,” Owen admitted. “I know I’m pissing them off by acting like I’m better than them, but the thing is, that I *am* better. I’ve got more power, more training, and more experience, even with my time away from the life. They’re good kids, and I respect Galvanize’s attitude, but at the end of the day we exist on totally different levels. I have no idea how to make that gap disappear, and if I try to fake it, I’m pretty certain they’ll hate me even more.”

“No, don’t fake it,” Lenny advised. “These folks already get shit on by Heroes who see them as sell-out wannabes. If you start acting fake they’ll think it means you’ve decided to placate them like children.”

“Then what’s my other option?”

“Tell them the truth,” Lenny replied. “Meet it head-on like you would any other challenge. Let them know you’re having trouble fitting in like you told me, except maybe don’t be quite such a dick about it. Then, and this is key, realize what a fucking schmuck you’re being.”

“Schmuck?”

“Titan, you’re a great Hero and an all-around unstoppable guy. No one could do your job like you,” Lenny said. He ran his hand through the wisps of hair that remained on his bald head; this part would require careful wording.

“Thank-”

“But do you think you could do my job?”

“Be an agent?”

“Yes, be an agent. Handle PR disasters, coach rookies how to deal with the spotlight, wake up to console grown men who show up with beer in the middle of the night. Do you think you could do my job better than I do?” Lenny was wide awake now, locking eyes with the man who could kill him in a single motion and refusing to blink.

“Of course not. I mean, you’re Lenny.”

“Good, there is a bit of humility left in that skull of yours.” Lenny let the staring contest lapse and leaned back into his chair. “Titan, you’re a fucking beast of a Hero; never let anyone tell you different. Thing is, your job is not to be a Hero: not with this team. Your job is to be their liaison. And you kind of suck at that job. Being a good Hero is a wonderful achievement, but it doesn’t automatically make you the best at everything. It just means when a

Super needs putting down, you're the guy we call. If you need an agent, you call me, and if your toilet won't flush, you call a plumber. None of us is inherently better; some jobs are just more prestigious."

"I get it: just because I'm good at my job doesn't mean I'm better at theirs." Owen had the sense to look at least somewhat ashamed.

"You're damn right. So, my advice to you is to get to know these people, find out all the areas where they can smoke your ass. Learn to respect them, because they deserve it, and the rest of your problems will solve themselves."

"Thanks, Lenny. I don't know what I'd do without you." Owen stood up to go, reaching for his beer.

"Leave the case," Lenny instructed. "That's quality stuff and I have some new clients coming by tomorrow that I'd like to woo."

"Your midnight consultation rates have gone up," Owen said.

"Economy's a bitch," Lenny replied. "Now go home and sleep. You're going to need your rest, because you've got a lot of crow to eat in the morning."

## 15.

When Hexcellent walked into the living room the next morning, she was struck with a smell that was foreign and familiar all at once. She'd been with Mordent Holdings as a PEERS for over two years, subject to their rules, restrictions, and endless examinations. One aspect of that included a carefully controlled and monitored diet to ensure that everyone on the team looked camera-ready at all times. This meant that in her time doing the job she'd somehow managed to forget this heavenly aroma's source as a result of scarcity. This morning, though, the memory came flooding back as she witnessed Titan add his latest batch of flapjacks to an already sizable stack.

"Morning," he greeted. "I made pancakes." He was dressed in sweats again, though this time they were topped with a cream-colored apron what was far too small for him. This was no surprise; Hexcellent recognized it from their linen closet. It was a communal apron they used when cooking, and no one else on the team had the same proportions as Titan.

"Galvanize is going to fucking shit when he sees those," Hexcellent said, walking over to examine Titan's culinary efforts. She was clad in a black tanktop and silk pajama pants with silver spiderwebs stitched across the legs, attire demonstrating her intention of lazing about for as long as she was able.

"Why am I going to shit?" Galvanize stepped in from the hallway. Unlike the other two, he was fully dressed for the day. "And what's that smell?"

"Pancakes," Zone told him. He and Bubble Bubble were directly behind Galvanize; evidently the trio had just finished something and were coming toward the kitchen together.

Galvanize frowned, the expression strange on his perpetually positive face. "Titan, we can't have pancakes. They aren't on the approved dietary restriction list."

"These are. They're some sort of hippie-whole-grain-low-gluten-low-taste-clusterfuck, but they pass the bar for acceptable breakfast. I even checked it out with Greene first."

"That was. . . quite kind of you." Galvanize headed over, with Bubble Bubble trailing close behind. Zone took his own time in crossing the room.

“It wouldn’t have been much of an apology if I made you something you couldn’t eat. And that’s what these are: apology pancakes. Last night I went for a walk and did a lot of thinking. What I ended up with was the realization that Zone was right: I have been thinking that I’m better than you four, which is stupid. You kids, sorry, you four do a damn respectable job and I’ve got no right putting myself above you just because we have different career histories.”

“Nice words,” Zone said. “But they don’t mean shit without action.”

“Zone, control yourself,” Galvanize chided. “Our teammate just gave an honest apology and is trying to make amends. That is not the sort of thing we stomp down, regardless of our personal feelings.”

“Let it go. I think Zone and I are going to have to square on some different issues sooner or later.” The last of the pancakes were pulled from the griddle and slid onto a waiting plate already piled high. “But he’s dead-right about words meaning nothing without action. Which is why I’d like you all to know something: my real name is Owen Daniels.”

Zone’s mouth had already been open, ready to snap something at him, but the words rotted on his tongue. Revealing one’s name was far more personal than a face. Faces were changeable and concealable; names were dangerous. Names opened the door to research, to history, to learning everything there was to know about a person. It was widely regarded as fact that the only people Heroes shared their real names with were their families and their teams.

“Tit- Owen, that gesture means the world to us,” Galvanize said. “Truly, it does.”

“It’s just a name,” Owen replied. “The pancakes are the good gesture, or as good as this healthy stuff can be. I already stuck some of those juices you stock and chunks of fruit on the table. I thought we could all have a team breakfast, then move on to the next part of my efforts to stop acting like a prick.”

“More than healthy pancakes and name-dropping? Sir, you do us too much honor,” Hexcellent said. Despite her words, she did come over and help him with two of the pancakes-bearing plates.

“What can I say? I’m a giver by nature.” Foul-mouthed and strange way of dress aside, Owen enjoyed his gothy teammate. She had the sort of spitfire nature he’d always been fond of. Hell, he’d liked one woman with it

so much he'd managed to convince himself he loved her enough to marry.

"So what's the plan then?" Bubble Bubble took her seat at the table, piling her plate with mostly fruits and veggies alongside a single pancake.

"That's up to you four," Owen said, putting far more than one pancake on his plate. Health-assurances aside, he suspected the bulk of the eating would fall on his ample shoulders. "I want to learn about each of you, understand how everyone works on their own as well as on our team. I don't even know what your jobs entail outside of actual response work, and that's something that needs rectifying."

"Sounds like setting you up for a shadow day is the best option," Galvanize said. "Unfortunately, today I've got a debrief meeting about yesterday's fire. Even if I thought it would be educating, only the team's leader is allowed to attend. Bubble Bubble, how about you?"

"Photoshoot. He's welcome to tag along, but it's just going to be posing for five or six hours."

"Let's call that our last resort," Galvanize said. He looked over at Zone, who was silently stuffing food into his mouth while purposely avoiding any eye contact with Owen. Had he been only a tenth of the leader he was, Galvanize would still have seen that situation for the train wreck it represented. Instead, he turned his gaze to the girl with ink-bottle black hair. "Hexcellent, what have you got today?"

"Decent assortment," she replied, mouth half-full of berries and pancake. "Doing a store promo, then a mini-photo-shoot with Spyda, plus a small branding meeting. All that paired with the usual shit, of course."

"Of course. Well, Titan, if you really want to learn more about what we do when not saving people, I think Hexcellent is your best shot today. That work for you?"

"If she doesn't mind, I'd love to tag along," Owen said.

"Fine by me," Hexcellent replied. "It'll be nice to have someone to carry my bags other than Big Henry. He scratches up damn near everything he touches."



## 16.

Owen was surprised to find a car waiting for him and Hexcellent. They'd finished breakfast and gotten into their respective costumes, then headed down to the street level. Hexcellent walked without pause to a dark sedan idling at the curb.

"You don't drive?"

"Company policy," Hexcellent sighed. "Two years ago one of their former PEERS got into a fender-bender with some old lady. She developed back problems, went after him and Mordent in court, and generally drummed up a lot of bad press, not to mention drained some cash out of their pockets. Now we're only allowed to use a car service, unless we're driving to an actual response in the approved vehicle. Keeps us from being liable."

"Also keeps you from going anywhere they don't know about," Owen added.

"For a guy whose whole career is built on having Armageddon-level muscles, you're pretty quick on the uptake." Hexcellent climbed into the back seat, followed by her massive coworker, and the car maneuvered back into traffic.

"I'm actually not Armageddon," Owen told her once they were buckled up. Laws were laws, even if he was effectively invulnerable. The minute a Hero began to think he was above them was the same moment his downfall began.

"Really? I thought you were this legendary dude with impossible strength."

"I am, but that doesn't change the fact that it's pretty much impossible for a strongman to be considered an Armageddon Class threat. We just don't have the damage capacity."

Hexcellent cocked her head to the side; today's blasting of makeup made her look like a somewhat befuddled bat. "Damage? Isn't the rating system like a power-level thing?"

"No, but a lot of people mistake it for that, even some Heroes." Owen tried to cross his legs in an effort to find a more comfortable position, but this

only resulted in him slightly bending the window lever. “People have tried putting a level system in place plenty of times, actually, it just never holds up. First off, we’re always learning about new people and powers that make us rethink things in terms of scale. Plus, it always goes to shit in that lots of powers negate or overwhelm each other. For example, a good telekinetic can knock most strongmen out of a battle by lifting them off the ground, even if the strongman would be rated higher in terms of raw power.”

“You’re explaining to me how there’s no level system to help me understand the level system,” Hexcellent pointed out. “I’ve got some old Algebra teachers you’d fit in just great with.”

“Sorry, I just wanted to show why measuring Supers by level doesn’t work. What you can measure, regardless of their power, is their capacity for destruction. As I recall, the default rule is it’s how much damage a Super could do if left unchecked for an hour.”

“Sounds sort of morbid, and that’s coming from a girl wearing zombie-themed lipstick.”

Owen nodded. “You won’t hear me disagreeing. It serves a purpose, though: knowing someone’s class tells you how dangerous they are. It informs on how we prioritize protecting civilians, minimizing property damage, and escalating force. There’s minimal need to try to cripple or kill a Standard Class threat if subduing is an option.”

“What if they’re higher up the chain?”

“Then we do what has to be done. No Hero, at least none that lasts, enjoys that part of the job. But if we don’t stop them, innocent people will die. Personally, I always try to subdue or de-escalate first for anything below Armageddon Class. Bear in mind, my power gives me that as an option. Others aren’t so lucky.”

“Jesus, and here I thought all you people did was pick kittens out of trees and foil bank heists.” Hexcellent’s eyes were wide, creating a strange contrast between the whites of her sclera and the ink-black of her makeup.

“PR departments try to de-emphasize that aspect of the job, same as with cops. It might be necessary, but that doesn’t mean people like to think about it.”

“No shit.” Hexcellent turned to look out the window for a bit, watching the buildings roll by. “So what are these classes, then? Like, where

would I fit in?”

“You’d be a Standard Class,” Owen replied. “Most Supers are. It means you can do some significant damage and are a danger to life; however, you’re not a threat to a large-scale area.”

“Great, I’m lowest rung.”

“Actually, that would be the NTC Class. It stands for Non-Threatening Combatant, though we just call them ‘knocks’ for short. That nickname comes from the fact that one little tap to the head can usually bring them down. They’re Supers whose abilities are in no way dangerous, meaning they have the same propensity for damage as a regular human. Healers, people with low-caliber display abilities, that sort of thing.”

“But Healers become Heroes, they can’t be that weak,” Hexcellent said.

“It’s not about weak or strong, just about immediate destructive potential,” Owen reminded her.

“All right: so it goes NTC, Standard, then I’m guessing there’s something between that and Armageddon.”

“Two steps: Demolition Class and Manhattan Class. Demo, which is my actual classification by the way, means a Super could level several city blocks if left unchecked. Manhattan means the level of destruction they can wreak would be roughly on par with a nuclear bomb. That’s why Supers like me never hit too high on the scale; we just can’t cover enough ground to be considered a massive threat.”

“Well damn. Here I thought we were at least getting a hot-shit Hero and you’re not even in the second to best class? Maybe we should see if Galvanize thinks you’re really cut out for the penthouse.” Hexcellent smiled at him, showing more warmth than she seemed to share with some of her other team members.

“You can try to throw me out, but I should warn you: I’ve kicked the dogshit out of countless Mannhattans and even a few Armageddons. They might be better at large-scale destruction, but I’m in the top when it comes to one-on-one.”

“Unless a telekinetic lifts you in the air,” Hexcellent reminded him.

“I said that works on most strongmen. I’m not among that number.”

“That so? Please enlighten me, great Hero, what secret technique do you use for getting out of such a precarious situation?”

Owen reached into the belt of his uniform and pulled out a few steel balls roughly the size of marbles. “I throw these at whoever lifts me. They’ll at least break the person’s concentration, and if I hit them, the problem pretty much takes care of itself.”

“No way that works. I’ve seen a bunch of telekinetic Heroes hold shields while doing other stuff. They could just block them.”

Owen slipped the balls back into his belt pouch and gave Hexcellent a smile of his own. “Shields, like everything else in this world, can only take so much. Put enough force behind it and the right blow can shatter them.”

“You’d have to be throwing pretty damned hard.”

“Unlike keeping my mouth shut, that’s one of the few things I do well,” Owen said.

## 17.

The store promo, as Galvanize had called it, turned out to be little more than thankless glad-handing at the opening of the latest Fiery Discussion, Hexcellent's most prominent sponsor. There was a small crowd there, no doubt drawn by the advertised sales and giveaways meant to promote the new store's presence in the South Brewster mall. A small black tent was partially obscuring the mall's walkway; it housed the store's staff, along with several corporate representatives gathered to greet the eager shoppers. As a representative of Mordent Holdings, the conglomerate that ultimately owned this "rebellious" company, Hexcellent was tasked with circulating through the meager audience.

More people recognized her than Owen had expected. This mystery resolved itself when he glanced through the glass storefront and realized she was heavily featured in posters on the walls. Even those who didn't seem to recognize her greeted Hexcellent with some warmth: that is, the males among them did. Hexcellent was pretty in a way that appealed to the store's particular clientele; at the same time, the way she used the store's products still showcased her natural gifts. True, she wouldn't be winning any classic beauty pageants even if she did scrub the makeup and tattoos away, but that was what they liked about her. She didn't look like a model grabbing a paycheck; she appeared to be the genuine article. Since Owen had seen her dress in similar fashions while on her off-time, he had no reason to suspect that wasn't the case.

"Nice costume."

Owen glanced down, noticing a gangly male somewhere in his teens staring up at him. Despite all the reasons he had to don his nondescript mask, Owen had shown up in full Titan uniform. He sat away from the corporate folks. As a Hero he needed to take care not to accidentally endorse their products, but he still drew attention as he towered over the rest of the crowd.

"Thanks. Do I look like the real deal?"

"I mean, it's close, but the real Titan used bolder reds and had different stitching along the seams. Plus, he was taller, not that you can really help that. Still, all in all it's a commendable job. I bet you could win a few prizes at conventions if you attended."

Owen suppressed the urge to frown as the teen wandered off to find a new novelty to occupy his time until the doors opened. On one hand, he was glad not to have been recognized. It helped that almost no one knew Titan was back. But. . . taller? It was those damn television cameras, always choosing the perfect angles, making him look like he was even bigger than he was.

“Anyone pieced together that you’re the genuine article yet?” Hexcellent asked, walking over with a water bottle in hand. It surprised him how few swears she’d used since they arrived, but he supposed even among this crowd certain personality aspects required corporate sanitization.

“Not so far,” Owen replied. “Though that last kid said my costume was ‘close.’ So, that’s progress.”

Hexcellent snorted, trying not to spray water from her nose then quickly turning away lest any of the audience should see her near-mishap. “It’s your own fault,” she said as she delicately wiped her face, careful not to smudge any makeup. “You’ve got that gray mask, you could have come semi-incognito.”

“Forget it; I’m here with you. We’re part of a team. Sooner or later people will realize that Hexcellent and Titan are working together. Think of how thrilled these folks will be when they can say they were at the first public appearance.”

“You severely overestimate how many fucks are given about our team.” Hexcellent caught the curse only after it had exited her mouth and glanced around frantically to make sure no one else had heard. “What I mean is, yes, they’ll shake my hand and all, but at the end of the day, that has way more to do with my face and body than with my professional exploits. Same is true for everyone on the team.”

“I disagree,” Owen replied. “You all save lives for a living. Just because this group doesn’t understand and respect that doesn’t mean there aren’t others who do. I bet at least one kid you’ve pulled out of a wrecked car or burning building has a poster of you over his bed.”

“Trust me; I’ve seen the sales numbers, and statistically your statement is probably true. Personally, I try not to think about all the other posters of me that get sold. You know, to people who don’t know my name. Gives me the creepy-shivers.”

One of the men wearing a collared shirt with the Fiery Discussion

emblem on it was waving Hexcellent back over. It seemed they were nearly ready to open the doors, meaning Hexcellent had to stand by to do another round of greetings and handshakes that lingered a bit too long. Owen watched her leave when his ears suddenly pricked up.

“Titan, are you able to take assignments?”

He didn’t jump in surprise at Dispatch’s voice humming in his ear this time; maybe he would get the hang of this again sooner than he thought. By plugging his earpiece in that morning, he’d put himself on the grid of Heroes without going officially active. While he didn’t anticipate a need so great they had to rally coverage, it was still his obligation to be prepared for such things.

Owen pulled a cell phone from his pocket and stuck it to his ear before he spoke. No need to make people worry that the enormous, muscle-bound man was also having a psychotic break. “I’m working as a Hero Liaison right now, so I’m not taking assignments unless there’s a severe shortage or tremendous threat. Then I’ll do my part.”

A slight pause came before Dispatch’s reply. “Status recorded. There is a disturbance some distance from you. It is escalating, but the responding Heroes are establishing control. Should you be needed, teleportation will be arranged. If you hear nothing from me in the next fifteen minutes, consider the issue resolved.”

“Gotcha. What is this situation, anyway?”

“Mechanical constructs with capable weaponry and high levels of adaptability. Appeared and began wreaking property damage roughly ten minutes ago in the south-western area of the city. Elemental Fury has now arrived on the scene and diminished their numbers by forty percent. Likelihood of your needed intervention is dropping, but stay ready.”

“Of course.”

Owen put the phone away since their conversation had momentarily ended. Dispatch wasn’t really gone; she never stopped being right there. She was simply not talking, at least to him. If Elemental Fury, Gale’s team, was as good as their reputation then he probably wouldn’t be needed. Even knowing that, Owen looked around to find the most likely route of entrance for a teleporter to take. In a real battle, nothing was ever certain, no matter how good the Heroes were.

Hexcellent looked up from her crowd and flashed him a pained oh-

god-how-much-longer-do-I have-to-do-this grin. He responded with a small wave, doing all he could to tamp down the sudden spike of pre-battle anxiety rising in his gut.



## 18.

When Dispatch's voice crackled in Owen's ear, they were outside the mall, only a few yards from the town car that would whisk them away to their next location.

"Titan, you have hostile constructs closing on your location. Elemental Fury led the counterattack to wipe out the first wave, but a second appeared and scattered in various directions. One cluster is on a path that will intersect with your location in less than five minutes. Can you respond?"

Owen had stopped walking when he heard Dispatch speak, causing Hexcellent to shoot him a look of confusion. He held up one finger, gave a small shrug of apology, then replied to Dispatch.

"I can. One the Supers from my PEERS team is with me; do we have time to get her clear?"

"Negative. The constructs caused several accidents, leading to traffic congestion on every applicable route to safety. We have responders working on clearing roads, but until they're done, getting in a car will put her at higher risk."

"Excuse me, did you just ask if I could 'get clear'?" Hexcellent said, narrowing her eyes and sticking a hand on her hip. "If something's going down, I'm one of the people helping, remember, dipshit?"

"We've got robots or something like it less than five minutes away. If they come, it's possible they'll go after you, and I don't want to get you in trouble for engaging in combat," Owen explained. "Unfortunately the roads are jammed, so you're stuck here."

"Well, that sucks. But they're coming to us, right?"

"That's what I'm told."

"Then if I get attacked I can respond in self-defense. Just because we can't start shit doesn't mean we can't end it when some other douchenozzle does." A wry, daring smile lit up her face at the prospect of sanctioned battle. Owen again found himself wondering why a woman like this hadn't found her way into the HCP. It was a curiosity that would have to be sated another time.

“All right, I’m ready to respond and I’ve got a PEERS with me to help with the civilians. What can you tell me about these things?” He turned away from Hexcellent, not because he thought his words would in any way be muffled, but rather as a polite way of indicating that he wasn’t speaking to her. Dispatch didn’t require any such indicators; she always knew what was external conversation and what was meant for her. It was one of the many strange, yet useful, aspects of the mysterious voice.

“You have four heading toward your location. They have strength and resilience on par with a Standard Class strongman, laser weaponry on par with a Standard Class blaster, and reaction speed at elevated-human levels.”

“If that’s all there is then I don’t see why they caused such trouble,” Owen prodded.

“They also show adaptability to tactics, learning from the mistakes of others. Given your skillset, I do not foresee it being an issue. The other unique capability of these constructs is that they show minor regeneration. Disabled units would reenter combat after being left alone for some time. They cannot heal beyond complete dismemberment or destruction, however.”

Owen stretched out his arms, tensing every muscle from his shoulder to his fingers. After a moment, he rose up on his toes, adding his legs to the procedure. He felt the mild strain in his tendons, and for an instant he was intimately aware of every fiber of muscle in his massive body. Ever-so-slowly, he released the stretch, pulling his arms back in and lowering down on his feet. It should only be a minute or so now.

“Hit them hard, hit them fast, and don’t stop until they are scrap. That it?”

“That will neutralize the threat. We have others trying to gain information out of their wreckage and systems, but I’m aware your talents lie in other directions. They have continued on their current course and will be breaking into your line of sight momentarily.”

With a squint of his eyes, Owen could make out the shimmering shapes of four sizable humanoids running toward him. They were big, probably a little taller than he was. Not that it would help them. He pulled back his left leg and judged the distance. It had been a while since he’d pulled this trick; Owen hoped he hadn’t lost the touch.

“Am I finally going to see the legendary Titan let loose on some motherfuckers?” Hexcellent’s tone was light but she’d positioned herself

several feet behind him. Her attention was split, eyes darting between her teammate and the mall entrance where shoppers were already beginning to line up and point.

“I’ll do my best to put on a good show, but to be honest, this is probably going to be a pretty boring fight. Stay ready, though; if any of them get past me, you’ll have to draw attention from the humans.”

“Big Henry ain’t exactly a subtle sumnabitch, if you hadn’t noticed,” Hexcellent replied. She hadn’t summoned any of her demons yet, but Owen had seen how quickly she could pull them. It was the right call; bringing them out might panic the civilians. Best to let him settle things quickly.

With a nod to Hexcellent and a minor grunt born more out of habit than effort, Owen pushed against the concrete with enough power that it cracked under his boots. The force of the jump sent him sailing forward in an arc more long than high, carrying him across the parking lot to where four metal behemoths were just arriving on the asphalt.

Whether by luck or skill, Owen hit his mark dead-on, landing only a few feet away from the cluster of constructs. The concrete sprayed them as he effortlessly tore through it upon landing. Before any of them had a chance to register him as a threat, Owen sprang. He darted up to the two on the left and slammed a hand into the torso of each. Flexing his fingers, he easily shredded their armored facades and gripped the firm inner workings that kept them moving.

His guess had been close on their size; each was nearly half a foot taller than he was. Despite this, he showed no apparent effort as he lifted the two constructs off the ground, spread his arms, and then clapped them together like two high-tech tambourines. Sparks and shards of metal rained down on Owen, who ignored it all just as he’d been ignoring the flailing blows that the two bots had been pelting him with since he arrived. He pulled them apart and banged them together again, and again, and again. After the fourth strike there was barely enough left to hold, let alone smash, so he dropped the remains of his first victims and turned to the other two.

This was the first time Owen got a good look at them, as he’d deformed the ones he held too quickly to get a mental picture. Each one possessed a small, dome-like head, as though someone had spray-painted a bowl and turned it upside down. They had awkward, triangular torsos and forearms that were vastly oversized and out of proportion. That anomaly explained itself quickly, as the one on his right raised its hands and fired red

beams at Owen's chest.

He'd forgotten Dispatch's warning about the lasers. Owen dashed forward to the one attacking him, ignoring the slightly-singed smell of roasting costume, and grabbed it by one of its triangular shoulders. If the robot had the capability of feeling surprise, it certainly didn't get an opportunity to do so. With his other hand snaring its waist, Owen ripped the metal warrior in half as easily as one would tear serrated paper. Just for good measure, he quickly tore it into a few more pieces before scattering the remains about with a whip of his arm.

Spinning on his heel, he found the last one shuffling on its feet. Dispatch had said these things learned and were adaptable. It was probably trying to compute a strategy to overcome him.

"Good luck with that," Owen chuckled. The robot stopped shuffling for the barest of instants, and Owen pounced.

It was too bad, really. He had wanted to put on a better first exhibition for his new teammate.

## 19.

“Are you completely invulnerable or some shit?”

Hexcellent had been largely silent after they had calmed the civilians and let a DVA cleanup team grab the robot scrap. She’d mostly just been skimming her phone and throwing occasional, furtive glances his way until they had hopped into the town car waiting to take them to their next destination.

“No one is truly invulnerable,” Owen told her. How many times had he used those words? Not only to fans or interviewers, but to upcoming Supers who hadn’t yet learned how important a lesson that was.

“Yeah, you say that, but those robo-douches were whaling on you the whole time you had them, and one hit you full-force with lasers that could tear through concrete and steel. That seems pretty invulnerable to me.”

“I never said I wasn’t tough; that’s part of my power. Invulnerable implies beyond all means of injury, and no one has that ability. No matter who you are, no matter how strong your power, we all have a weakness.” Owen paused for a moment and considered her words. “Wait, how do you know what their lasers could do?”

Hexcellent waved her phone, which was really no more than a big screen, in his face. “It’s all over the web. Those things did a shitload of damage before Heroes got there, and even then managed to put a few out of the fight. You went through them like Thai food through Zone.”

Owen scrunched his brow in response.

“Oh, right, you haven’t been here for Pan-Asian cuisine night. Just be glad we all have our own bathrooms. Also, the point was that you fucking wrecked them.”

“I had the benefit of knowledge on my side. The others went in blind, but I got to know what they could and couldn’t do. That let me tackle them efficiently, without having to worry about them secretly being explosive or having enough firepower to bring me down. First response is always the hardest, most dangerous work,” Owen explained.

“Yeah, I get it, humility, politeness, and blah blah blah. Did they at

least get all of those things?”

“They did.” When Owen had told Dispatch about bringing his down, she’d updated him on the rest of the threat. The second wave had been smaller and less organized than the first; by the time a crew was picking up the remains of his fight, the rest had already been terminated.

“What do you think they wanted, anyway? To rob the food court?”

“Honestly, I think they were a test run,” Owen replied.

“Wait, that was a fucking beta trial?”

“It’s my theory.” Owen glanced out the window, marveling at how quickly they’d gotten the messes cleaned up and traffic flowing. “Those things were strong, but they had some serious design flaws. Add in the lack of a clear objective, and it points to someone seeing how his first batch of bots stacked up against the town’s Heroes. You’d be surprised how many tech-genius Supers use the exact same opening gambit.”

“Oooh, or what if the robots sprang to life and got away from him? They surged out of the laboratory, hell-bent on destruction of the human world. Titan, you may have just helped stop the robot-apocalypse.” Hexcellent reached over and patted him on the head, stretching her long arms to their limit. “Good boy.”

“You just pretty much drift along in your own world, don’t you?”

“I’m a quasi-celebrity. I think we can both agree that’s my right.” Hexcellent stopped patting as the town car whispered up to a curb. Before she could reach the handle, the door swung open and a hand literally covered in tattoos reached in. It delicately took Hexcellent’s hand and helped pull her out of the vehicle as Owen emerged on his own side.

He surfaced to see Hexcellent lip-locked with a man whose bald head and face were nearly as tattooed as his hands. After a kiss long enough to register as uncomfortable for all bystanders, the two finally parted.

“What kept you?” The tattooed man had a slightly southern twang to his voice, the sort of lingering accent that belonged to people who tried to remove it from their voice. Owen might not have noticed it, but his time with his ex-wife, Sally, and her south Texas family had trained him to pick up on the vibrations.

“Robots causing traffic,” she replied. Hexcellent turned around and

pointed at Owen. “This big bastard is Titan, our team’s new Hero Liaison. Titan, this is Spyda, my boyfriend.”

“Pleasure to meet you.” Spyda walked around the car and grabbed Owen’s vast hand in an enthusiastic shake. The Hero was a bit taken back at how friendly this man who looked like an advertisement for biker gangs was being.

Hexcellent seemed to read the expression on his face, even through the mask. She explained, “Spyda is a guitarist for a hardcore metal band. Don’t let the look fool you, he’s actually a fucking softy.”

“But let’s keep that between us. Image and all to consider, I’m sure you understand.” Spyda released Owen’s hand and turned back to Hexcellent. “Darling, I hate to rush you, but the photographer doesn’t have much time left and we’ll both catch heat if the shoot isn’t done.”

“Lucky for you, my hot ass is always camera ready,” Hexcellent replied. “Titan, you can hang out in the prep room if you want. We shouldn’t be more than an hour.”

“You two go on ahead, I’m going to take a walk,” he said. “I’ll be here when you get out.”

“See you then,” Hexcellent called as they head toward the front door of the large office building.

“It was wonderful meeting you,” Spyda added before they vanished behind the frosted glass door.

As soon as they were gone, Owen turned and headed up the street. He’d seen an internet café on their way over, and Hexcellent had piqued his interest to see whatever footage was already online. Back in his day they had to rely on the scrap footage put together from cameras sewn into the team member’s costumes. Now, with a whole world watching, it would be interesting to look at an attack from so many different angles.

Besides, his experience told him that this wouldn’t be the last rampage of robots from whatever low-rent techie had cobbled them together. Best to see as much as he could and be ready for next time. If these things had really brought other Heroes down, Owen had a feeling he would be called in a lot sooner when they resurfaced.





## 20.

When Hexcellent emerged from her photo shoot, Owen was already waiting by the town car. Despite his best efforts at the internet café, he hadn't been able to pull up much more than he'd learned from Dispatch. The civilian videos and pictures seemed to capture a few interesting moments of the robots fighting Heroes, but nothing that gave him information on their abilities beyond what he'd experienced personally. Of course, that didn't mean such video didn't exist, only that it wasn't easily discoverable. Despite the advances in technology since he left the life, he suspected the DVA's attitude on showing the public confidential information hadn't changed.

"Sorry we ran over," Hexcellent said, sliding into her seat. "That photographer was a shitshow. Had me changing outfits every five minutes and getting into impossible positions. If she weren't so damn good I'd have told her to fuck off like twenty times."

"Don't worry about it, I found a way to kill time."

"Let me take a shot in the dark: you spent it trying to learn more about those bots you fought." Hexcellent flashed him a cocky grin as the town car began the drive back to the Mordent Holdings office.

"Am I that obvious?"

"Obvious seems like a mean way to put it. How about we say dedicated?" Hexcellent pulled her phone out and began checking mail and messages. "You've been with us for a few days now, and I've only seen you really light up two times: when you were pulling that fire-girl from the building, and when you were tearing those scrapheaps new metal assholes. After you darted off as soon as we left the car, it didn't take a lot to figure out what was up."

"You're pretty observant," Owen replied, glancing at her out of the side of his eye. Smart, determined, not shy about confrontation, and with an ability that showed strong potential. The more time he spent with Hexcellent, the more she seemed like a candidate for the HCP. It was certainly possible she'd rejected that sort of life, preferring the more pacifistic work of being on a PEERS team, but he had trouble buying such an idea. The girl had a streak of grit and violence running through her; a trait like that usually led to a job where it could be expressed.

“Let’s not get heavy on the compliments; like I said, you didn’t really make it hard.” Hexcellent’s eyes widened a touch as she stared into the depths of her phone’s screen. “Say, when you were researching, did you notice anything interesting about the fight at the mall?”

“I didn’t look it up,” Owen said. “Since I was there for all of it, there wasn’t anything I needed to know. I figured the time was better spent reading up on the first wave of attacks.”

“Ahhh. That explains it.” Hexcellent put her phone away and tried to keep a straight face, though a defiant smirk kept worming its way across her mouth.

“Going to tell me what’s so funny?”

“Hell fucking no. You can wait until we get back to the penthouse. This is too good to spoil.”

Owen considered pressing the subject, but thought better of it. Hexcellent was willful and stubborn; she’d demonstrated that since he first arrived. If she thought it was more fun to wait, then that is exactly what she would do. Besides, the day had gone pretty well. May as well let it end on whatever positive note she had in mind.

Hours later, he would look back on that naivety with the clarity of hindsight and wonder when in his absence he’d allowed himself to get so stupid.

\* \* \*

Lenny popped an antacid as he watched Gale walk over to him. Though her costume wasn’t especially sexualized, the woman had a certain appeal that no amount of clothing could bury. In his younger years, when libido was able to fight with bottom-lines and ethics, Lenny had tried to woo a few female Heroes. He’d even pulled it off a couple of times, but it never ended well. He was as married to his job as any of them, and when that was the case, the pressure got to be too much for a romantic relationship to bear. Still, seeing Gale stride across the conference room in Elemental Fury’s headquarters made him wish, just a little, that he was still young and dumb enough to swing for the fences.

“Gale, you look lovely, as always.” Lenny rose from the serviceable chair he’d been sitting in, taking her hand and shaking it firmly. While some female Heroes liked a warm welcome and perhaps a kiss to the cheek, Gale

was all business.

“Lenny, a pleasure to see you.” Gale took her own seat, and Lenny followed suit. “I apologize for making you wait; the construct attack caused our whole team to be delayed.”

Lenny waved a hand through the air like he was trying to smack an invisible fly. “Please, it’s nothing. When you work with Heroes, you learn to write your appointments in pencil. There are far more important things out there than me; I’m just thankful you were willing to take this meeting at all.”

“Birdsman and Granite hold you in high esteem,” Gale said. The barest traces of a smile crested her lips. “Though I must admit, my own agent cursed you from here to the heavens when I told him I was taking a meeting with you.”

“Mick’s a solid guy, but he knows how to hold a grudge. Ever since a few of his A-listers decided to come over to my camp, he’s been convinced I’m out to steal every client he’s got.”

“And is that what brings you here today?” Gale asked.

“If I thought I had a shot at pulling it off, you’d better believe I’d try and woo you,” Lenny admitted. “But I do my research, and that means I know you’re the loyal type. So long as Mick does right by you, you’re going to stay with him. Of course, if he ever fails in that regard, expect to get some very nice wine with my card attached.”

“At least you’re honest about your intentions. Shall we get down to the business of why you’ve come here, then?”

“Gladly.” Lenny shifted slightly in his seat. The chairs were made for tall, powerful people and didn’t accommodate his small and round frame as adequately. “I’m here about you requesting to do an ability assessment with one of my clients.”

“I haven’t asked any. . . wait, you rep Titan?” The shock on her face was easily visible even through her mask.

“Always have, from the day he first stepped out of the Sizemore Tech HCP. Even sent him birthday cards during what I’ve chosen to think of as his ‘hiatus.’ I’d tell you he’s a good man and is out here trying to make right by the world, but I doubt you’d really take my word for it.”

“Agents aren’t exactly renowned for their truthfulness,” Gale said. “I

take it you're here to try and talk me out of the assessment, to tell me that I should just leave Titan alone and forget about him."

"Talk you out of it? Why in the nine hells would I want to talk you out of it?" Lenny reached for the briefcase at his side, pulling it up and slapping it on the table. "Elemental Fury, the current top team in Brewster, testing out Titan, a living legend come forth from the past. People would sell their kids to see that kind of show. And not the black sheep, either, kids they really like."

Gale felt herself grow suddenly uncomfortable. Despite being bigger, stronger, and overall more powerful than the bald man sitting before her, Gale had the unmistakable sensation that he was trying to make a play for control of the situation.

"Hero assessments are generally held in private," she said.

"Oh sure, when they're real assessments that makes total sense. But this isn't a real assessment, is it? This is a pissing match you set up so that you could try and intimidate Titan into toeing the line."

"I wouldn't-"

"You don't need to deny it or defend yourself to me. Honestly, I love the idea. The only problem is that you didn't think big enough. If we're going to do this, we're going to make it profitable." Lenny pulled out a stack of papers and shoved them over to Gale. "Basic contracts regarding filming and distribution rights of the event. Show them to Mick, but even he'll admit I gave you a damn fair shake. Once you've signed we'll get the scheduling worked out."

Gale flipped through the pages, scanning paragraph after paragraph of small type and large words. Finally, she set it down and looked the short man dead in the eyes.

"Why are you doing this?"

"Because you created an unfair situation," Lenny replied, snapping his briefcase shut. "If the assessment is private and you make Titan look like shit, then you get what you wanted: the old dog will feel like he's not up to the life anymore. If it's private and he stomps you all, however, nothing really bad happens to you. A little wound licking and maybe some humbled egos, but nothing horrid. To me, that seems like bullshit. Putting pride on the line is only a good way to gamble when both go in at equal stakes. Now, with an audience, if Titan handles that assessment like a pro, you get to look like start-

ups who can't hold a candle to the old guard. You can still call it off if you want, of course, but if you go forward with it then it will be under my terms."

"Don't you mean Titan's terms?" Gale asked.

"That big lug has no idea I'm doing this. He'll probably shit a chicken when he finds out. This is me, all me, doing my job and protecting my client's interests." Lenny hopped out of his chair, briefcase clutched firmly in hand. "Tell Mick to fax those over when they're ready. He knows the number."

"You may be the most ruthless agent I've ever spoken to, let alone dealt with," Gale said, still a bit dumbfounded by Lenny's surprise strategy.

"It's also why I'm the best." Lenny pulled out a business card and set it on the table. "Just in case you want to shop around for a new rep once this is over."

"I thought you said there'd be wine, too."

"Give me a little credit here," Lenny said. "It's already been delivered to your room."

## 21.

As soon as he stepped through the door from the elevator hallway to the living room, Owen realized something was up. Granted, Hexcellent's inability to stop smirking and snickering throughout the entire drive back had clued him in that he was in for some sort of surprise, but seeing Mr. Greene standing there, with Galvanize nearby, drove the point the rest of the way home.

"Oh shit, did I screw something up?" Owen held the door for Hexcellent, who scampered through and immediately made a beeline for the large television on the other side of the room. She snatched up the remote from Zone, who was sitting next to Bubble Bubble as she surfed the web on a slim tablet.

"Not at all," Galvanize quickly assured him. "This is something that we knew would happen eventually. "It was part of the package when we chose you to fill the role of our Hero Liaison."

"While that is true, we also had planned a nice, well-framed release of the information specially designed to cast you in a positive, crowd-tested, sentiment," Mr. Greene added. He wasn't angry; men like him were too proper to ever get angry. Instead, he was "putout" : a careful combination of annoyance, discontent, and resolve. Owen had known a lot of people like Greene in his life, and he'd prefer someone who called him a fucker and took a swing at him far above people who got put-out.

"Could someone at least tell me what I'm in trouble for?"

"You're not in trouble, dumbass. You're just not our little secret anymore." Hexcellent made this announcement just before she drilled her finger into the television's volume button, filling the room with crystal clear sound from expensive surround-sound speakers.

*"-which were cleaned up less than an hour later. Neither Elemental Fury nor Shifter's Assembly were able to be reached for comment.*

*"If you're just joining us, today in downtown Brewster several automated robots attempted to carve a path of destruction before being thwarted by several of our local Hero teams. Later tonight our team will tell you what this most recent uptick in violence will mean for your weekend.*

*“In related news, the most surprising part of today’s attack was not the robots themselves, but who appeared to help stop them.”*

The picture on the television switched from the anchor with perfectly-sprayed hair and unnervingly white teeth to shaky footage clearly taken by someone with a cell phone. It only took Owen a glance to recognize what was happening on the film. It wasn’t hard to remember; after all, he’d been there only a couple of hours ago.

*“Sources have confirmed that the man in the picture is in fact Titan, a Hero formerly associated with the Chicago area and known for both his strength and the scandal that drove him out of the public eye over a decade ago. Already people are having powerful reactions to his reappearance;; let’s go to Janice-”*

Hexcellent hit mute, then turned to Owen. “Seems you still look enough like yourself to get recognized.”

Owen allowed himself a brief moment’s chuckle. “I bet that kid from the store opening is pissed he didn’t grab an autograph.”

“I’m glad you two find this so amusing, because your little escapade has torched our entire plan for announcing your new position and controlling the spin of the story,” Mr. Greene snapped. “Dozens of carefully planned, focus-group-tested events and promotions all rendered useless because you couldn’t stop yourself from punching some robots.”

“Hang on now, are you trying to give me shit for doing my job? Hero Liaisons are still Heroes, we have responsibilities to the public. I’ll say I’m sorry that this made controlling your precious image harder, but if you’re waiting for me to apologize for stopping threats to innocent people and property then you better have a toilet and a novel handy, cause it’ll be a while.”

“No one is upset with you for stopping those things,” Galvanize said, hurriedly stepping in. “Mr. Greene just wishes you’d told us as soon as it happened so he could have gotten ahead of the story. It’s my fault as much as anyone’s. I should have briefed you on that policy before you and Hexcellent went out this morning. It just didn’t occur to me that anything would happen.”

“Are you kidding?” Zone said from the couch. “How could it not? Once he was away from us I bet Titan couldn’t wait to get the cameras on him. He probably called in favors specifically to have them routed to him, all so he could play big bad Hero for the camer- OW!”

The last bit came as Hexcellent took the remote still clutched in her hand and brought it down on Zone's well-gelled head. It struck so hard that the back flew open and one of the batteries popped out.

"Cut the fucking temper tantrums, Zone. He didn't do shit. Titan came with me, stayed properly to the sidelines, and minded his manners the entire day. The only reason he took on those robots is because they were literally coming right for us. I've watched videos of what those things did to downtown, and if he hadn't hung around to tear them up, that mall would be in pieces and at least some people would be dead. Even at that, he still took the time to try and get me away to safety before fucking those things up. Be a pissy bitch all you want about real shit, but there was a situation that needed handling and Titan handled it. End of story."

For a moment, the air between the two teammates grew very tense. There was a second, a very long and dangerous second, when Owen thought Zone was legitimately going to take a swing at Hexcellent. Thankfully, the moment passed, and Zone leaned back into the couch, a sour expression on his face but otherwise silent.

"Right then. Since I've already spoken with the DVA and they confirmed that you were pulled in out of necessity, you didn't violate any protocol with your actions." Mr. Greene didn't need to add the "this time" to his statement; his tone already implied it perfectly. "Please do a better job of keeping us in the loop in the future, though. I'd like to remind you that it isn't just our 'precious image' that I'm here to manage, it's yours as well."

"Appreciate the concern, but I already pay someone for that."

"And I'm sure he's just as good as an entire staff of trained and experienced public relations professionals," Mr. Greene scoffed. "Regardless, you need to tell us when these incidents happen, *especially* when one of our people is on the scene with you."

Owen bit back his planned retort, a very graphic description of what Greene could do to his "public relations professionals," and made himself calm down. While Owen was the new guy and couldn't be held too accountable for not calling things in, Hexcellent didn't have his excuse or his level of fame. Making waves might end up with her head going below water, and he wouldn't be responsible for that.

"I'm sorry I didn't call it in," Owen said slowly. "In the future, I'll make sure to report these sorts of things as soon as they happen."



“That’s all I wanted to hear,” Mr. Greene said. “Now go fill out an incident report. I have damage control to do.”

Owen just nodded. He didn’t trust his tongue with the freedom to speak.

## 22.

Owen had barely finished filling out the incident report when he heard a soft knock on his bedroom door. After no one immediately came through, he realized the person on the other side was waiting for permission, not announcing their entry. These kids were a lot better about personal space than his first Hero team had been, though given the way some of them got along, that might have been out of necessity.

“Come in.”

The door opened and Galvanize stepped through, already suited up in full costume. “Titan, we’ve got some work to do.”

“No voice over the speaker this time?”

“Mr. Greene only uses the emergency alert system when we have assignments of a time-sensitive nature,” Galvanize explained. “Today we’re going downtown to help with the cleanup efforts. No one is in immediate danger.”

“Why would we go help with cleanup? There’s already people for that.” Collateral damage from fights between Supers was a constant issue in any major city, even with Heroes doing their best to keep situations contained. Decades ago, some enterprising people with useful abilities had recognized that this situation had the potential for profit and founded companies specifically to handle the cleanup. With a few Supers whose talents lent themselves to quickly moving or fixing rubble and a teleporter who had decent range, anyone could land contracts with a city to fix what the Supers broke.

“They handle the large-scale issues: clearing streets and making sure no buildings come crashing down. There’s still a lot left to do after a conflict like what we saw today. Streets to sweep, glass to clear, small repairs to be made, that sort of thing. The cleaners are there to make sure the city stays up and running, they’re far less concerned with helping everyone impacted by a battle.”

“Well, that seems a lot like bullshit to me,” Owen said. “I thought the city paid them to take care of everyone.”

“Some services do exactly that, but they also charge more for it. Brewster’s mayor and city council decided to use companies that get the bulk of the work done and let the citizens handle the small stuff on their own.”

Owen let out a sigh and got up from his chair. Once upon a time that sort of thing would have set him off on a tirade, but he was too old and too jaded to get worked up over it now. Government officials were always going to find ways to move money from essential services to things they thought were more worthwhile. . . usually their own pockets. Heroes might be able to lift buildings and defy gravity, but no one could keep greedy, self-serving shitheads out of government. Some things were simply too impossible.

“How long do I have to change?”

“Fifteen minutes. We’re meeting in the garage again.”

“Gotcha. I can be there in five.” Owen grabbed the papers off his small desk and walked over to Galvanize, thrusting them toward the younger man. “Here’s my report about the robots. I think it’ll get Greene off my ass.”

“Mr. Greene is just worried about the team,” Galvanize assured him. He took the papers from Owen and gave them a quick scan. “But speaking of Mr. Greene, I feel it only appropriate to warn you that there will be a very large media presence when we get downtown. He wants you out in the limelight under the company’s approved plan.”

“Of course he does.” Owen shook his head; it was becoming more and more apparent that Greene was going to be a problem. It wasn’t an issue when he pulled this crap in regards to Owen’s Hero Liaison duties, but if he got uppity every time Titan was seen doing Hero work then they were going to quickly come to an impasse. “Don’t worry about me and the cameras; I used to deal with them all the time. Are you guys going to be okay, though? There’s going to be some people mighty pissed off that your Hero Liaison is me.”

Galvanize smiled, showing two perfect rows of bleached-white teeth that were both impressive and unnatural. “Oh no, you mean people might not think that highly of us? We might become the butt of the Super community’s jokes, or treated like a bunch of loser wannabes? How on earth would we ever handle something like that? Personally, I can’t even get out of bed in the morning unless I’m roused by screaming fans outside my window.”

“Okay, smartass, you made your point. I guess being associated with me won’t be that bad.”

“I’m sure we’ll still catch a fair amount of crap,” Galvanize said, tucking Owen’s report under his arm. “We’re just used to muddling through it. Being a corpie isn’t a glamorous life, despite what the companies are hoping for. But at the end of the day we make the world a better place. No amount of people being jerks or looking down on us can take that away. I’m sure I don’t have to explain that to a Hero.”

“I’ve known a few who could have benefited from hearing that,” Owen replied. “I’ll be down in the garage in a few minutes, just need to change into a shirt that doesn’t have robot laser scorch marks.”

“And here I didn’t take you for the vain type.”

“Like I said, I used to do this a lot. What we have today is an unveiling, and you always go to those looking your best,” Owen said. “As my agent told me back when I started: you want to look clean, put-together, and ready for anything. You want to make the regular people fall in love and the criminals shit their pants. Always be bigger than life.”

“Sounds as though your agent and Mr. Greene would get along.”

“Yeah, I sort of doubt that,” Owen replied.

“Well, do what you need to do; just be ready to go soon. All media attention aside, there really is work to be done.” Galvanize took Owen’s report and headed out of the door, leaving the large man to change.

Owen walked over to his closet and pulled it open. He still had four unmarred Titan shirts left. The things were durable as all hell, but no one doing Hero work could keep an outfit clean for long. One of the first things a Hero learned to budget for was all the new costumes they would need. He’d thought six would be enough to last him a while, but between Alexandria’s flames and the robot’s lasers, his shirts were dropping fast. Tonight he’d call Lenny and see about getting hooked up with a new distributor.

In the meantime, he had rubble to clear and cameras to greet.

## 23.

Despite Galvanize's warnings, there wasn't an enormous media presence when the giant SUV pulled to a stop on a slightly-cracked downtown street. In fact, there were fewer reporters than people in costumes. Many of the latter had trash cans and brooms positioned near them. Owen recognized a couple of people from the recent research he'd done about Brewster's current lineup (being caught off guard by Gale had been quite the wake-up call) and was surprised to realize there were actual Heroes involved in the efforts and not just other corpies. He wondered if Chicago had been worked by cleaners who handled the little stuff, or if he'd just been too caught up in the action part of the job to realize there were people in need even after the fighting was done.

Though there were fewer reporters than Owen had been expecting, it seemed that those who were present really had been waiting for him. No sooner had his giant boots touched down on the broken pavement than a flurry of people with inhumanly perfect skin and professionally tailored outfits descended on him. It was like being attacked by department store mannequins. Owen held up a single hand and they halted their charge, though it didn't keep their voices from ringing out.

"Titan! Is it true you're really the original Titan and not a legacy?"

"What Hero team are you looking to work with?"

"Have you come here to be a solo Hero?"

"Is there any truth to rumors that you're still involved with Tower?"

Owen's fist tightened at that last one, a gesture he purposely hid by shifting his hand down to his side. Things hadn't gone well for Colby, or Tower as the world knew him, after they'd been caught. To hear his name come out of the mouths of one of the same sort of media vultures that had helped tear him down. . . it was a good thing Owen had learned a lot about self-control in his time away from the life.

"I'm the real Titan, the one and only, with all the good and bad that brings with it," he told them. "I've decided to come out of retirement, and Brewster seemed like a great town to work in. As for Hero teams, I won't be needing one of those, nor I am truly working solo. I'm proud to be working as

the Hero Liaison for the fine PEERS group you see around me. Now, if that settled everyone's questions, we really should start helping clean up all this broken glass."

One of the reporters, the same one who'd asked about Tower, broke away from the group, getting in so close that Owen could smell the recently-chewed mints on the man's breath.

"Titan, what about the rumors that you and Tower have-"

"You're new to this job, right?" Owen stared down at him, doing his best to keep his face impassive.

"That's right! I'm Kip Sterling of the Brewster Evening Edition, the hardest hitting-"

"Uh huh. I guess either your production team doesn't like you, or they thought it would be a good initiation prank to keep you in the dark." Owen gently spun the man around and pointed to the other reporters, who were maintaining a safe distance from everyone in a costume. "See how none of them kept pressing things once I told them we were done, or even kept coming forward when I held up my hand? Why do you think you were the only one to rush over?"

"Because Brewster Evening-"

"Wrong. Because when a Hero is on any kind of duty, the press is only allowed to be as close as we say they can be. Just like cops don't let you in to active crime scenes or dangerous situations, Heroes have to be able to work without worrying about innocent people getting hurt."

"But that's only for when there's an actual fight going on," Kip Sterling said, finally losing some of the naïve luster in his piercing blue eyes.

"Or for when we're doing heavy lifting, or suspect a threat isn't entirely neutralized, or that an area is unsafe for those without proper training or abilities. I can keep going, but you get the point. Yes, this area doesn't have any robots terrorizing it that we know of. That doesn't negate the broken glass, uneven concrete, and various bits of debris, not to mention the Supers using their abilities. We all have skills and clearance that let us walk around in these sorts of places safely. You being here puts your safety at risk, and as a Hero I can't very well have that."

Owen patted the reporter very gently on the back; the last thing he

needed was to accidentally bruise this little asshole and have that be a headline story. “Now, go back to the sidelines with the others. I’ll overlook the mistake this time, since I believe that’s what it was, but next time be more cautious. On scenes like this, unless a Hero specifically gives you permission, going where you aren’t supposed to is a serious crime that will get your station heavily fined. I’ve seen it happen before, and they are never happy about it.”

Kip Sterling seemed like he was about to voice another objection, but a glance to his fellow reporters quelled his resolve. They were all shuffling about, avoiding eye contact and refusing to come any closer. Kip Sterling wasn’t secure enough in this job to risk bringing down a fine on his station. The truth of the matter was that Brewster Evening Edition was a relatively new show, which was why he was trying so hard to get a sound bite for it. This also meant that if the program caused the network too much trouble, they’d have no issue canning it. Kip slunk back to the sidelines with the others, leaving Owen alone with his team.

Galvanize approached as soon as the reporter was gone. “I thought you said you knew how to handle reporters. That one looks like someone stole his teeth-whitening trays.”

“You’re one to talk, Smiley. Besides, I think it went pretty well. I could have slapped that guy with enough fines that his stations wouldn’t let him mop the floors, let alone hold a microphone. Instead, I let him off with a warning and explained the situation to him. Yeah, I took no bullshit, but I did one of their own a kindness. That sort of thing shows itself in the way they write up the stories.”

“And you didn’t think you needed to answer more than three questions? Even we usually do full five-minute interviews after big rescues,” Galvanize said.

“Of which I’m guessing maybe three seconds end up being used, if that.” Owen grabbed a trash can from the back of the vehicle, hyper-aware of photographers snapping dozens of photos of even that mundane an action. “Dealing with the press is like being a performer; you leave them wanting more. The less they know, the more they’ll speculate, and the more they speculate the more coverage they’ll devote to that speculation. Sometimes it’s good, and sometimes it’s bad, but either way it’s coverage, so I think Greene will be happy.”

Galvanize thought it over for a moment. “I don’t know if Mr. Greene

is ever actually happy. Hopefully he'll be ambivalent. I think that's his version of happy."



## 24.

With the media handled, or at least subjugated enough to where Owen no longer considered them an issue, the team turned their attention to tidying up the area ravaged by the robots. The cleaners had done an exceptional job of making sure all the roads were clear and the buildings stable. They'd even rebuilt several structures before calling the job done. Nevertheless, there was still a fair bit of debris strewn along the sidewalks and in the drainage gutters of the streets. Shattered glass was abundant, as well as small chunks of concrete. Some pieces were quite sizable, the sort that would have required more than one person and might have resulted in an injured back; Galvanize sent Owen and Bubble Bubble to deal with that particular obstacle.

Owen's method for handling them was to simply lift the bits of concrete effortlessly off the ground and set them into the trash can he'd been provided with. Initially, he'd worried that it would fall apart when it was filled and he tried to lift it, but that concern proved groundless as the repository held together flawlessly. These kids really did have the best of everything, even trash cans.

Bubble Bubble made slower but steady progress. She would summon one of her energy spheres, carefully encasing the bulk of the debris, then move it over to her own trash can and let the sphere dissipate. Her speed didn't bother Owen—she was using her abilities the best way they'd function—but he did notice she seemed to take a lot of time between each piece of debris, fixing her hair and repositioning herself several times. At first he thought she was trying to find the best angle of approach for her pieces. By the fifth time it happened, Owen had recognized the all-too-familiar behavior.

"Are you posing?" He set the sizable bit of broken building onto the top of his trash can, keeping his eyes on her the whole time.

"Of course I'm posing." If she was bothered by being called out on that fact, she didn't let it show. In fact, she kept the same poised, neutral expression that she'd been wearing pretty much since Owen met her. Even her smiles and reactions were subdued, as though she were constantly on a job interview.

"Let's back up. Why are you posing? This isn't a shoot, it's work."

“For some of us, those are one and the same,” Bubble Bubble replied. “Many of my sponsors are clothing and makeup companies, which means I have to be camera-perfect at all times. It wouldn’t be proper for someone to capture an unflattering photo of me.” A sphere crackled into existence around several small but jagged pieces of concrete and floated on a slow path toward the trash can.

“I really hope you’re joking. What’s the worst that could happen if someone took one bad picture of you?”

“I’m not concerned with what could happen. I’m worried about what couldn’t.” Even as she manipulated the sphere through the air, Bubble Bubble was able to keep her tone and expression perfectly placid. “A proper presence at all times is what opens doors to other opportunities, like modeling jobs outside of the costume, and those are a stepping stone to roles in television or cinema. Constant composure and beauty are the hallmarks of a successful media icon. We can’t all afford to brush off the press at our convenience.”

She set her latest load into her trash can and looked down. “Pardon me. I’m going to take this over to the large dumpster.” A new sphere appeared, this one encasing the whole trash can, and Bubble Bubble walked off toward the industrial-sized dumpster that had been set up to hold the accumulated debris.

“Don’t let it bother you; she’s a career girl.” Hexcellent came over, broom and small bin in her hands. Useful as her demons were, none were suited for delicate work, and they already had enough lifting power without Big Henry. “B.B. climbed her way up from a bit role on a minor PEERS team in South Dakota. The girl has ambition like a mother fucker. She’s probably the best person on the team at working crowds and cameras.”

“So this job is just. . . what? A step on the path?”

“If you know of another career that gets a Super media exposure and access to professional PR teams *and* minimizes personal risk, then I’d love to hear it,” Hexcellent said. “I give her shit at home, but honestly I sort of get it. The girl wants to go to the top, and as long she keeps her ass working hard at this job while she’s here then I don’t care where she goes next.”

“You make it sound like you aren’t even friends,” Owen replied, lifting a few chunks of debris into his trash can.

“We’re not. We’re teammates. I trust her to do her job and she trusts me the same way. Before I came on to the team there was someone else she

trusted with that duty, and when she leaves for greener pastures I'll get used to someone new. That's all work, though; our personal lives stay way the fuck separate. It's the same for basically everyone on the team, except for the monthly game nights that Galvanize always tries to organize."

That Galvanize would try and get his team to interact socially didn't surprise Owen at all; what shocked him was the idea that any team could work so well together yet be so separate. His Hero groups had been thicker than family. Then again, they'd also been facing the very real threat of death every day. That sort of pressure forced bonds between people, making small differences irrelevant.

The more he thought about it, the more he realized the truth in what Hexcellent was saying. Even today, during breakfast, Galvanize had gone over everyone's schedule and they'd all been doing different things. Helping clean downtown was the only team activity of the day, and it couldn't possibly have been planned. These four were living entirely separate lives that happened to brush against the others' on occasion.

He grabbed his trash can and began hauling it to the dumpster, lost in thought. Maybe this was good enough for most of them, but Owen deeply suspected Galvanize wanted more. As the Hero Liaison, it wasn't technically under Owen's purview to deal with that sort of thing.

Not that he gave a shit. Owen hadn't left retirement to sit on the sidelines when he saw a problem. If something needed doing, he was damn sure going to do it. The only hurdle to jump was figuring out how.

## 25.

“I saw it on the news, but I couldn’t believe it until I confirmed it with my own eyes. Titan, *the* Titan, back in costume. And doing the work of the little people no less.”

Owen felt his spine stiffen as soon as the voice reached him. He’d been bent over to grab a particularly large piece of rubble that required both hands to keep balanced when those words had washed over him like a wave from the distant seas of his past. Slowly he rose, turning his body until the speaker was in view. It was an older man, one who actually showed his years, unlike Owen. He wore a costume fashioned of red, gold, and white, with lots of burst and flare patterns woven throughout the fabric. A beaming smile was partly concealed by a bushy mustache as he stared across the slowly dissipating wreckage.

“Topsy?” Owen crossed the small gap between them. He towered over the mustached man, who generously could be measured at five-foot-three-inches tall. “Topsy, when the hell did you move to Brewster?”

“’Bout five years ago. After my wife passed—thank you for the flowers, by the way—the city was too full of old memories. Besides, I wanted to be nearer to my kids. That’s a boring question, though. I’m much more interested in what brings *you* here.”

“It’s a long story, and not the sort you tell when there are reporters about,” Owen said. “The short version is I’m here as a Hero Liaison.”

“I already knew that part. Course, I checked up on you as soon as I heard you were back.”

“Titan, we need your help hauling the dumpster. . .” Galvanize trailed off as he jogged over, realizing that his team member was engaged in conversation. “Sorry, I didn’t mean to interrupt.”

“Nuttin to apologize for. Job always comes first, no matter what that job might be.”

“Topsy, this is Galvanize; he leads the PEERS team I’m a Hero Liaison for. Galvanize, this is Topsy. He was-”

“Titan, please. A Hero like Topsy needs no introduction.” Galvanize

stepped forward and took the older, shorter man's hand. "It's a real honor to meet you, sir. The Gentle Hammers were one of my favorite Hero teams growing up."

"Look at that, some of the young ones still know us old dogs," Topsy said, giving Galvanize's hand an enthusiastic shake. "And he even knows a Gentle Hammer other than Titan! Been a while since anyone bothered remembering that."

Owen winced inwardly at the remark, even though he knew Topsy hadn't meant it to be painful. The Gentle Hammers had been his first Hero team, founded mostly from Sizemore Tech graduates he'd kept in touch with through their intern years. In the beginning, they'd all been more or less unknowns. When their prestige grew, it grew as a team. Those were the golden days, back when everyone had been working together and happy. Unfortunately, Titan's reputation soon began to outpace—and eventually eclipse—the rest of the team's. The Gentle Hammers were still around when his scandal broke, but he, Topsy, and Shock Lock were the last founding members. The team had officially dissolved a few years after he went into exile.

"Topsy, I'm still not sure how I didn't know you were here. I just checked on all the active Heroes in Brewster last night," Owen said.

"Ah, but I'm not active anymore, am I? No, I'm working as an advisor and trainer for one of the local Hero teams. I can still jump in if the need demands, though these bones don't move as quick as they used to. Unlike you, some of us have to actually cope with getting older."

"If you try and tell me that a little thing like age has slowed you down then I'll grab you by your ankles and shake you until you admit you're a mimic," Owen threatened.

"Let's say it's half getting older and half getting less suicidal. I'd like to make it to see my grandkids one day. Plus, it's nice to pass on some of the lessons we earned through blood and broken bones to the next generation. The ones I'm coaching are plenty powerful, but heaven almighty, are they stubborn and impulsive."

It took all of his self-control for Owen to bite back the chuckle that wanted to escape his lips. Topsy had been the most easily provoked member of The Gentle Hammers, often barreling into fights without so much as basic recon. It was only an incredible ability, loads of skill, and a fair smattering of

luck that had kept him alive.

“I’m sure you’re teaching them a lot about control,” Galvanize said. If there was even a hint of sarcasm in his words, he buried it under a mountain of sincerity. “May I ask which team you’re an advisor to?”

“Please just don’t say it’s Elemental Fury,” Owen mumbled under his breath.

The mumbling wasn’t quite as soft as he’d intended, as Topsy replied, “No, they’ve got plenty of retired members of their own to do the advising. I’m helping a newer team, Wild Bucks: mostly offensive types with a couple of Supers for doing defense. They’re getting better, but what I wouldn’t give to snag a Subtlety Hero for them.”

“I’ve heard of Wild Bucks,” Galvanize said. “They came on the scene last year. Lots of physically-based abilities, not unlike The Gentle Hammers.”

“Similar, to be sure. If you’re ever up to stopping by and giving them some pointers, Titan, I’m sure they’d be grateful for the tutelage.”

“Much as I’d love to, I’m already in over my head with the local Hero teams,” Owen said. “I’m supposed to do an ability assessment with Elemental Fury soon, unless Lenny can somehow talk them out of it.”

“Talk them out of it? That doesn’t sound like the Lenny I used to know,” Topsy replied. “If anything I’d expect him to turn the whole production into a circus and take a cut of everything from the clown makeup to the elephant shit.”

“Damn it. . . that does sound a lot more like Lenny. Maybe I should call him.”

“We’ll be done here soon, Titan.” Galvanize’s tone was polite, like he was gently reminding someone of a schedule conflict rather than instructing his teammate to stay on task. “The rest of the evening is yours, barring any unforeseen crises, of course.”

“Up for a drink, Topsy?” Owen asked.

“Another time. I’ve got my team scheduled for some training drills tonight. After how they performed against today’s robot attack, they need to polish their skills.” Topsy nodded to Galvanize, then headed off down the street.

“I didn’t see Wild Bucks on the news reports,” Galvanize said once he thought Topsy was out of earshot.

“They were some of the first to respond,” Owen told him, hours of reading up on the incident finally paying off. “None got killed, but most were incapacitated within the first few minutes. The media leaving them out of the story was actually a pretty kind gesture, one I’m sure Topsy had a lot to do with.”

“Sounds rough.” Galvanize turned back to the street, where things were slowly beginning to look less chaotic. “Speaking of rough, we still need your help with the dumpster. It’s a beast; none of our strongmen can get a grip on the whole thing, so we’re coordinating a group effort.”

“No problem,” Owen said. “Just tell me where the team needs me. That’s what I’m here for.”

## 26.

“Yes, but. . .”

“That isn’t how I wanted. . .”

“Of course I trust you. . .”

“Now you listen here. . .”

“*Fine!* Just do whatever you want.”

Owen gripped the phone tightly as he jabbed the button to end the call. Only its hardy construction kept it from flying to pieces. As soon as he’d gotten back to the penthouse from the cleanup, he’d called Lenny, who had unapologetically confirmed his worst fears. Not only did he not get the assessment with Elemental Fury canceled, he managed to make the situation into a bigger shitshow than it already was.

Lenny could run his mouth all day about how Gale might back down now that odds weren’t stacked in her favor; they both knew it was bullshit. Gale was young, powerful, and just successful enough to be insecure about her position. She wasn’t going to back down from a damned volcano, let alone some washed up Hero and his bald agent.

With more care than he felt like using, Owen set the phone down. The last thing he needed to add to his frustration was the mountain of paperwork Greene would surely make him file to replace any of the room’s furnishings. No, he needed to wind down a little, to take his mind off the growing mountain of crap he had to deal with.

For a fleeting moment, he considered hitting up Brin’s Gate, the Hero bar Gale had shown him. It was tempting, but the risk of running into her was more than he was willing to undertake. If she’d been around Lenny today then she was likely to tear Owen apart the moment they laid eyes on one another.

Instead, Owen changed into sweats and headed off toward the gym. While they didn’t have anything that would challenge his lifting abilities, it still calmed him to do basic aerobics and calisthenics. The focused monotony cleared his head, and if he kept at it for enough hours, he occasionally worked up enough of a sweat to release some endorphins.



No sooner had he opened the gym's door than Owen regretted his decision. Leaping around the rescue simulation part of the gym was Zone, normally spiky hair matted to his scalp thanks to the abundance of sweat pouring from his body. Briefly, Owen considered backing away from the door and hoping his teammate didn't notice. He decided against it, though, walking in with just enough noise to be sure Zone knew he was no longer alone. If the kid wanted to hate him, that was fine, but Owen would be damned if he let that affect his choices. Besides, if he really wanted to help Galvanize pull his team together, he would need to deal with this issue sooner or later.

"Evening," Owen said, keeping his greeting as neutral as possible.

Zone did a flip off a fake roof, landing lightly several feet away. When he came down, an incredibly short wince of pain shot across his face. Most people wouldn't have noticed it or recognized it for what it was, but Owen knew in an instant. He'd spent too many years around other Heroes, people whose jobs demanded a physicality that was impossible for most to manage for long. The kid had worn something in his body down and he was trying to keep it hidden.

"What are you doing here? None of the shit we have could train you."

"Maybe I came for the pleasant atmosphere," Owen shot back. He regretted it as soon as he'd spoken; he needed to try and mend this bridge, not torch it further.

"That got wrecked the minute you walked in." Zone grabbed a towel and started to head for the door.

"All right, kid, enough of this crap. You got something you want to say? We're right here, just you and me. No one to tell you to calm down, no one to hold you back. Either say your piece or quit all the sniping bullshit."

Zone froze midway to the door and looked back over his shoulder. "Go eat shit. I don't have to do this your way. If I want to keep calling you out every chance I get and never tell you the reason why, I damn sure will."

"That would be a great point, except that you've been trying to lay into me since I got here. Only circumstance has stopped you. I'm not telling you to do it my way; I'm trying to give you the chance to do it yours." Owen crossed his arms and met Zone's withering glare. "But if you want to keep up the snide ridiculousness, go ahead. I somehow doubt you'll get any harder to ignore."

“You just think you know everything, don’t you?”

“I know you’re pissed off at me, sorry, at Titan, and clearly have been long before I was ever on your team. What’s the deal? You think I’m a shithead for walking away? That’s fair. Dislike that I lied to the public? Tough shit; I was lying to people that I cared about way more, myself included. Hell, maybe you just don’t like gay people.”

“Fuck you!” Zone yelled, all composure gone as he stormed back toward Owen. “You really want to do this? Fine! I hate you—not Titan, *you*, Owen—because of what you could have done. Look at you! You’re tough, strong, and intimidating as all hell. If you’d come out of the gates as gay, you could have given an icon to all the Supers out there who wanted to be Heroes but were scared their orientation didn’t fit the masculine ideal. You could have been the symbol they held up to show that being gay didn’t mean they couldn’t kick ass. You could have given people hope and encouragement and instead you did *the exact fucking opposite*! After your scandal, every openly gay Hero has had to live in the shadow of the bullshit you pulled.”

“Yeah, that’s a damn good reason to be pissed.” Owen’s voice was calm as he stared at the red-faced young man in front of him. Zone had gotten so worked up during his speech that a few flecks of spittle had struck Owen on the chest. Owen had expected to get pissed himself when this finally came to a head, but instead he felt oddly serene. Zone hadn’t said anything Owen hadn’t told himself countless times over the past decade. He already knew he’d fucked things up. Being called out on it didn’t change things.

“Is that it? Is that your apology?”

“No, Zone. I was raised that we don’t sincerely apologize with words; we do it with actions. Words are washed away by time and memory. They’re easy to create and easier to forget. I owe an apology to a lot of folks, the ones I lied to and the ones I let down by leaving. I’m saying I’m sorry to everyone, you included, by going back out there and trying to do good. You may never accept my apology; I know plenty of people won’t. That’s damned sure your right, but I’ll be out there making it regardless. That is literally all I can do.”

“I don’t think it will ever be enough,” Zone said, the fire and energy gone slowing draining out of him.

“Probably not. Doesn’t mean I don’t have to try.”

Zone turned to walk out of the gym, slowly now, not even bothering to storm away. Owen called to him.

“Who was it? Friend, family-”

“Big brother. Strongman, like you. His powers are worlds above mine. Easily could have been a Hero and helped a lot of people. Instead, he does construction in Ohio.”

With that, Zone exited the gym, leaving Owen alone with his thoughts and his guilt.

## 27.

Owen walked in the living room the next morning to find two men he'd never seen before talking to Galvanize. The taller of the two had dark hair and the kind of wiry frame Owen associated with easily excitable computer guys. The shorter one had brown hair and a rounder build. They both were sporting crisp white lab coats, and the taller one held a clipboard in his hand. At first, Owen took in this sight with curiosity bordering on interest, but everything inside him turned to panic when he was struck by an overpowering realization.

He wasn't wearing any kind of mask.

Instincts kicked into gear. He spun around, ready to dart down the hallway and pray they hadn't noticed him. Before he could, Galvanize's voice rang through the room.

"Titan, good morning! Come over here and meet the docs. I doubt you'll need them, but you're going to see them around from time to time."

Owen tried to steady himself. These men were probably on staff, meaning they'd signed the kind of nondisclosure agreements only large corporations and sociopathic villains could conjure up. Galvanize wasn't an idiot; he'd already shown a lot of deference to Owen's need for privacy and hiding his identity. If he was calling Owen over, then there had to be some sort of safety system in place. Still. . . it wouldn't hurt to double check before he turned his face back toward them.

"Morning, all," Owen said, keeping his back facing the group. "Galvanize, I came down without my mask on. Is that going to be an issue?"

It wasn't Galvanize who replied, but one of the men in lab coats instead. "Titan, you have nothing to worry about. My assistant and I have been signed to so many contracts and clauses that if we leaked even a fraction of what we've dealt with here we'd bankrupt ourselves, our families, and at least six generations of children."

He was probably exaggerating, but the man had a kind tone and a bit of humor in his voice. Owen could see himself getting along with this fellow. Besides, if they were going to be around a lot he'd have to get used to it eventually.

“Six generations, huh? These bastards really don’t mess around.” Owen turned and walked over to the two men, the docs, as Galvanize had called them. He shook their hands, starting with the taller of the two. “Nice to meet you both. I’m Titan.”

“Edgar Willoughby,” said the tall man. Owen recognized his voice as the one that had spoken already. “But I absolutely insist you call me Edgar. This is my assistant, Thaddeus Kirkland.”

“Please, just Kirk,” said the shorter man. “Thaddeus is a family name.”

“I understand how that goes, Kirk,” Owen replied.

“The docs here work for Mordent,” Galvanize explained. “They do a lot of stuff, but one of their responsibilities is taking care of us. We’re all subjected to weekly physicals to make sure we’re still in tip-top shape.”

“Precisely,” Edgar agreed. “We can’t very well have one of Mordent’s wonderful PEERS going out to help someone only to slip a disk or blow a joint. As folks entrusted with rescuing people in peril, their health is of the utmost concern.”

“Plus we have to make sure they haven’t slipped up on their body-fat percentages,” Kirk added.

Edgar threw a quick disapproving look to his assistant.

“What? We check it. You and I know it, and the PEERS sure as heck know it since it’s in their contracts. Titan is exempt, but I’m sure by now he’s realized there’s certain conditions put on the rest of his team.”

“It’s fine. I figured that out just from the fridge,” Owen said. “No way four young people in this line of work would willingly refuse to stock any beer. Surely at least one of them would want to enjoy unwinding with a drink if they had any say in it.”

“Yes, well, while the superficial aspects are less intrinsic to the accomplishment of their duties, we are still required to monitor them,” Edgar admitted. “And on that note, I believe we are due in Hexcellent’s room. Galvanize, we’ll see you in about half an hour. Titan, it was a pleasure to meet you.”

“Quite an honor,” Kirk added.

“Same here,” Owen said.

The two men headed off down the hallway Owen had just emerged from, presumably on their way to Hexcellent’s room.

“I know what you’re thinking, but they really are nice guys,” Galvanize said once the docs were gone. “Last year I seriously messed up my ankle while helping out with a multi-car pileup. The team was due to put on an exhibition at a sporting event two weeks later. Mordent had sunk a lot of money into it and the exposure was going to be huge, so they expected me there, fully-functional ankle or not. They wanted the docs to give me a clean bill of health so I could make the show. Edgar and Kirk told them to blow it out their ass, that if I tried to do anything too active I would cause serious, long-term damage. Mr. Greene finally got the company to spring for a healer so I could be properly patched up in time for the event.”

“Damn. This doesn’t seem like the kind of company that would take that shit lightly.”

“I’m sure they wouldn’t, but the docs are way too important to lose over something like that. They’ve both involved in all sorts of Mordent projects, the kind of stuff so classified I probably don’t even know about the floor it’s on.”

“And they use these valuable assets checking on four Supers’ fat levels?”

“Edgar and Kirk demanded the right to be our physicians,” Galvanize told him. “Like most scientists, they’re fascinated by Supers. We’re the biggest mystery to come along in millennia, and people are dying for answers about us.”

“I’m sure they’re smart guys, but I’m not holding my breath on them cracking it,” Owen said. “We had hundreds of guys in lab coats trying to figure us out back in my day too, and they never made much progress.”

“Sooner or later, someone will. I’m pulling for the docs. At least they treat us like people instead of experiments.”

“That is harder to find than it should be,” Owen agreed. “Anyway, what’s on the docket today besides getting you all checked out?”

“It was supposed to be another splintered day,” Galvanize said. “However, after yesterday’s unexpected reveal, Mr. Greene decided it was

best if we had some more team exposure. We all need to be in costume and ready to go by nine.”

“Not going to tell me what we’re doing?”

“I’d rather wait until the whole team is here and deal with it once,” Galvanize said.

“That kind of thing?”

“Unfortunately, yes.”

## 28.

“As you all know, as of yesterday our team has been under increased media awareness,” Galvanize said, eyes sweeping across his team as he spoke. Bubble Bubble was paying attention, though from the disinterested expression on her face it was clear this either wasn’t news or wasn’t news she cared about. Hexcellent seemed somewhat curious, despite her constant yawning. Zone was the least expressive of them all. Usually he was preoccupied with shooting dirty looks at Owen; today his anger seemed to have simmered down a few degrees to the point of general disinterest. How long that would last was anyone’s guess.

“Consequently, Mr. Greene feels it’s important that we appear as a team for the next few days. This might be an opportunity to catapult our brand awareness. As we’ve discussed, putting together a united front only increases our appeal.” This was not mere speculation on Galvanize’s part. Countless market research studies had proven that while the occasional lone Hero could gain renown, people by and large tended to prefer to see their Supers in teams. It only followed that this mindset would apply to PEERS as much as it did to Heroes.

“You’re beating around the bush,” Hexcellent accused. “What do we have to do?”

“There’s a charity event coming up in several weeks. It’s a joint venture of the Super Athletics Association, companies like Mordent, and individual Heroes. There are meet-and-greets, competitions, exhibition matches, and of course the SAA will have plenty of sports going on. Generally the only PEERS teams allowed to participate are those that have a substantial fan base of followers. Today, Mr. Greene informed me that we will be signing up for it with his blessings.”

Both Zone and Hexcellent groaned loudly, and even Bubble Bubble lifted an eyebrow and pursed her lips in an expression Owen assumed was distaste.

“What’s wrong with doing a charity event?” Owen asked.

“Nothing’s wrong with helping charity,” Hexcellent said. “But this means we have to be around Heroes. The nicest of them just ignore us, while some are outright dickholes. They even treat the players from the SAA better



than us, because for some reason that's considered a more respectable job."

Owen reflexively felt himself about to stick up for those in his profession, but his brain stopped his tongue before it could wag. Only a week ago he'd thought of these people as pretenders, children playing dress-up and trying to grasp at a title they hadn't earned. How would he have treated them if he were on a Hero team working this event? Hexcellent was right; he probably would have just ignored them, at best. Instead of disagreeing with his team, he'd be better off finding out what they were in for.

"What exactly is our role at this thing?"

"That, we are allowed to determine individually," Galvanize said. "As I said, there will be plenty of events and activities we can participate in, though Mr. Greene has requested that you not sign up for meet-and-greets."

"Don't think anyone will want Titan's autograph?" Owen said, only half-joking.

"More that he feels Titan is better seen larger than life for right now. If you're on the ground, talking to people, inevitably someone will use it as a chance to protest or cause controversy. He thinks you should be doing things instead, reminding people about the power that made them adore you in the first place."

"That's a pretty fair plan and assessment," Owen said. It was exactly the sort of thing Lenny would have told him to do. Greene might be an anal-retentive overbearing jerk, but it was somehow slightly reassuring to know he was at least competent at his job. "Anything in particular he'd recommend?"

"No, only that showing up other Heroes would likely lead to bad blood, so perhaps something cooperative or with the SAA would be best."

If Greene didn't want him showing up other Heroes then he was going to be beyond pissed about Owen's assessment with Elemental Fury it. He briefly considered making a comment in this vein but thought better of it. He was still hoping that little fiasco-to-be would fall through and become a non-issue.

"Guess I'll do something with the SAA," Zone said. "Maybe join a baseball or basketball team. I've always been able to crush at sports; I should at least be able to hold my own there."

Owen nodded agreement, not wanting to stir up Zone so soon. It was

unlikely that he'd really be able to play on the same level as SAA athletes, whose abilities had been specifically recruited and trained for use in sports, but now wasn't the time to bring that up. At least in basketball or baseball Zone was less likely to get injured. If he'd tried to play football, Owen would have had to step in.

"I'll see what they've got," Hexcellent remarked. "My summons are damned versatile, just a matter of seeing what suits them best."

"As Hexcellent said, I too will see what's available," Bubble Bubble said. "Though I doubt my abilities are suited to anything particularly spectacular. Perhaps there is an administrative or service role I can assist in."

"Mr. Greene assured me that we would all be able to find events we were suited to," Galvanize told them. "Remember, we're representing Mordent and there will be a lot of eyes on us thanks to Titan, so whatever you do, make sure you can do it well. This is a big break for all of us; we shouldn't waste it."

"Gotcha, kick ass and take names," Owen said. "Is there a website for this or something? How do we sign up?"

"They have a remote service for Heroes, but we'll be going down to the organization headquarters to volunteer in person," Galvanize said. "That's why I gathered everyone in full costume; the press will almost certainly be waiting when we do so."

"Let me guess: Greene told them we would be there."

"Of course *Mr.* Greene did," Galvanize said. "He wants us as much in the public eye as possible. Which means everyone needs to have their PR faces on as soon as we arrive. Anyone needs to do touch-up before we go?"

His question was met by a combination of silence and half-hearted head shakes.

"Right then: everyone head on down to the van. We have press waiting for us; we should at least try to be prompt."

## 29.

Unlike the night of the fire, Galvanize kept the SUV at a low speed as they wove their way through the streets of downtown. This was as much out of a concern for safety as it was for appearance. In truth, the address they were heading to was within walking distance from the Mordent Holdings building, but that would have meant several members of the team showing up sweaty and tussled. It was fine to look that way on the job, especially after particularly impressive rescues, but today they needed to arrive looking their best.

He pulled the SUV into a conspicuously open street spot outside several large brick buildings. From how close it was to the small cluster of reporters waiting nearby, Owen suspected it had been saved especially for them. It would provide a great shot, the team stepping out of their vehicle with skyscrapers jutting into the sky at their back. The media wanted a crack at him, and they were playing ball with his team to get it. Owen would have to be careful how he handled them; he might be used to getting savaged by the press, but he'd rather not see his people go through it.

"Out of curiosity, what charity does this benefit anyway?" Owen asked, staring out the window as cameras flashed and microphones emerged.

"Proceeds will be split up," Galvanize told him. "Some will go to Dream Granters, the company that organizes Hero visits to terminal children, and some will go to Shelby's House. They help Powered's whose abilities make it hard for them to find work or housing and provide services like counseling."

Bubble Bubble let out a small sigh. "Sick kids I can see helping, of course, but it seems like they could have found a better cause than Powered's."

Owen felt a familiar anger start to burn in his stomach, but before he could decide whether it was worth the blowback to speak, Hexcellent took her own action. From her position in the backseat, she leaned forward and flicked Bubble Bubble forcefully on the ear.

"Ow!"

"You deserved it. Don't be a bitch."

“I was not ‘being a bitch.’ I was just saying that there are other causes out there that might need the money more.”

“Doesn’t matter, we’re not the ones doling it out,” Galvanize told her, unbuckling his seatbelt. “Our job is just to participate and raise as much cash as we can. It also won’t hurt us to look good doing it.”

Everyone but Owen paused to do a last-minute mirror check in the SUV’s visors or carefully-stowed compacts. Only after each member was certain they looked their best did the team finally pop open the doors and emerge.

Immediately, the press members surged forward, the clacking sound of shutters filling the air. Owen noted the reporter from yesterday, Kip Sterling, stayed right in the center of the pack. Clearly he was determined not to slip up and make another rookie mistake. Good for him; Owen had given that same speech to a lot of other ambitious media hounds only to see them keep right on breaking rules. That strategy never ended well.

It was less intense than Owen had feared. No one peppered him with questions or shouted accusation like back in his Hero days. Of course, during those times they were trying to get information about wanted criminals or destroyed buildings. Now they were just getting some shots of him with his new PEERS team going in to sign up for a charity event. The stakes weren’t exactly the same.

The questions did still come, just without the aggression he was accustomed to. Owen smiled, made eye contact, and kept his damn mouth shut. If Greene wanted them to be good, then Owen wouldn’t hand over any ammunition. A well-edited sound bite was a PR mortar shell when put into skilled hands. Until he caught up with Lenny and got a sense of where he wanted the story to go, it was best to give them nothing. Owen knew that if he wanted the right outcome then he needed to be the one to create the narrative of his story.

Galvanize was getting a few questions as well, mostly about which events Titan would be signing up for, though a few were about the team as a whole. He answered several, always polite and deferential, but kept the bulk of his attention on herding his team toward a large wooden door in one of the larger brick buildings. It took some doing, but eventually they made it and Owen easily pushed the barrier open. He expected the press to pour through it, like water through a funnel; however, they remained stationary as his team began to enter. Clearly whatever deal Greene had struck ended at the door.

Before Owen could make his way through, an unfortunately-familiar face popped up in front of him, microphone clutched in a sweaty hand. Kip Sterling had put himself ever-so-slightly between Owen and the door; he had just enough mass and was positioned just so that he was noticeable without seeming as though he intended to physically bar Owen's way. It was a ballsy move, and from the nervous fear he was trying to keep off his face, Kip clearly knew that. Still, he stood his ground as the larger man stared down at him, refusing to yield. Owen was tempted to brush him aside, but he had been thinking about the importance of keeping on the media's good side. Besides, he respected this little guy's guts.

"Yes, Kip?"

"I was just wondering what you're hoping to accomplish at the charity event," Kip said. Beads of sweat stood out on his forehead and the microphone shook just a touch. He really was desperate for something to bring back to the station. He'd even lobbed a big softball of a question, open-ended and with a positive connotation.

"Obviously our biggest, most important goal is to help raise as much money as possible for these wonderful organizations," Owen replied. He knew he should cut it off there; it was a great line that couldn't possibly be misinterpreted. Owen knew that because he'd played this game so well for so long back in his original Hero days. It was why he'd distinguished himself from his first team, why his star had risen so high. He always had a good gut sense for the right things to say. Yet now, staring down at Kip's shaky microphone, Owen realized for the first time that he didn't want to be a media darling again.

He wanted to be Titan, on his own terms.

"But as a secondary goal, I hope for the chance to kick some serious ass."

Owen slid past Kip, whose eyes were lighting up like flickering fluorescents, and stepped into the building. Greene wasn't going to like that, and Lenny might not either, but Owen didn't really care. He'd only told the truth, after all.

### 30.

When Owen got to Lenny's office, he was braced for a tongue-lashing. After the event signup, which had been mercifully quick, Owen and the team had headed back to their home. No sooner had they walked in the door and turned on the television than they saw Titan's face staring back at them. His voice filled the room, answering Kip's question eloquently and tacking on the bit about ass-kicking at the end.

Owen barely had time to regret that outburst before Lenny called, calmly demanding Owen be at his office within the hour. Calm Lenny was usually a bad sign. Cursing, drinking, complaining, anxiety-ridden: these were all forms of Lenny that meant he had things well-under control. Calm Lenny meant business, and all too often that business involved a serious ass-chewing.

Owen walked through the door to the lobby, ducking slightly to avoid smacking his head against the frame. He would have suffered no damage, but he'd have been on the hook for repairs. Titan merchandise didn't exactly fly off the shelves anymore, so he wanted to keep his costs down.

It was a good thing he was already ducked, too, because what he saw in the lobby nearly made him jerk his head right back up.

Lenny's office door was open and the small man was sitting inside, talking to another Hero that was already seated. Owen might not have recognized her even a week ago, despite the amount of media saturation she'd achieved, but after meeting Gale up close there was no mistaking her. Owen stepped through the empty lobby, into the office, and shut the door behind him.

"Afternoon, Lenny. Gale." He took a seat in one of the sturdier chairs, doing his best to keep his face neutral. If she was here to call off the assessment, he didn't want to do anything to make her change her mind.

"Always a pleasure, Titan," Gale replied. Judging from the flat tone of her voice, if she considered this a pleasure then Owen would have hated to see how she reacted to an inconvenience.

"Gale here has come down to finalize the discussion of the ability assessment in person." Lenny was all business, not even bothering with any

pleasantries. “Despite what I, and her own agent, have advised her, she is intent on going forward with this little spectacle.”

“Up until this morning, I was seriously considering taking it off the table,” Gale said, turning to face Owen. “That was until I saw his little interview. After that robot attack I thought maybe you really were trying to lie low and do some good. You managed to avoid charging into the spotlight like I expected. But no, the moment you get a few drops of media juice going, you hand them a sound bite that you know they’ll play over and over. You’re exactly what I feared you’d be: a showboat that puts his profile over the job. Well, I’m going to lower that profile, and thanks to your agent I’m going to do it with countless people watching.”

“Gale, come on; it was one line. I was there to sign up for a charity event and I let my tongue get away from me. You really don’t want to do this,” Owen said.

“I’m telling you right now that I do. We’re getting this done, and within the next week. Your agent has a list of my team’s availabilities. Find one that works, or so help me I will personally use my connections to bury you in red tape and bullshit.”

“What does this accomplish? Really, tell me that. If I do well, you’ve done the exact opposite of what you claim to want, and if I shit the bed all you’ve done is prove you can take a Hero two decades your senior.”

“When we decimate you, it will prove that your legend is all fluff. There will be far less cause for the press to care about your antics, and without their attention I expect you’ll soon shrivel up and vanish, just like you did before.”

Gale stood to leave, but Owen was on his feet faster.

“So you want to drive another Hero out of town? Remind me: which of us is the one who cares more about the media than the job?”

“I want to rid my town of a man who has too much influence and power and not nearly enough integrity to know how to use it.” Gale stared up at him, refusing to budge even an inch. “We both know it’s just a matter of time before your fame-whoring causes you do something stupid and get innocents killed. I’m making sure that you never get the chance.”

“And this has nothing at all to do with the prestige you think your team will get by embarrassing the legendary Titan?”

“I won’t stand here and be insulted by such ludicrous insinuations,” Gale snapped. “Unlike you, I have people to help.” She wove her way around the large man and stormed out of the office, slamming the lobby door behind her.

With Gale gone, Owen slowly lowered himself back into his chair and looked at Lenny, who was placid as a monk on morphine.

“That woman is not fond of you,” Lenny said at last.

“I think she hates me more than your ex-wife hates you,” Owen added.

“Don’t be silly. She didn’t even take a swing at you, let alone reach for a knife. She’s nowhere near that level of loathing. . . yet.”

“Damn right ‘yet.’ What the hell am I supposed to do? If I go into that assessment and throw it, then the Titan name gets even more run through the mud than it already has been. I mean, for all the shit that gets hurled about, the one thing no one can ever say is that I wasn’t a capable Hero. On the other hand, if I go in and tear her team apart, she really will hate me until the day one of us dies. I’d rather not have an archenemy that’s also a Hero so soon into my comeback.”

“It does complicate matters,” Lenny agreed. “Just out of curiosity, you didn’t mention the chance of legitimately getting shown up in either of your assessments. Did that not even strike you as a possibility?”

“I read up on Elemental Fury, including what they can do. So, honestly, no, it didn’t occur to me.”

“Me either,” Lenny said. “You’re in a real pickle here, no doubt, and it’s even worse now that there’s a giant audience contractually attached to the spectacle.”

“Thanks again for that, by the way.”

“My pleasure,” Lenny leaned back in his chair, still exuding endless rays of calm. “And while we’re on the subject of thanking each other for things, why don’t we have a nice long chat about that little quote you gave the reporter.”

Owen swallowed hard and looked down at his boots. This day was just getting worse by the hour.



## 31.

Owen was halfway back to the Mordent building, brisk evening air flowing around him as he jogged, when a noise suddenly crackled to life in his ear.

He tensed, waiting for Dispatch's voice to broadcast through. Since he wasn't registered as currently active, whatever she was tapping him for had to be serious. He was either the only one close enough to respond or others had already failed to contain the situation. Even if it was protocol, Owen had a feeling stepping one foot further into what Gale considered her turf would destroy whatever shreds of a chance there were for peaceful cohabitation. He'd have to deal with that later; in the moment doing his job was the only thing that mattered.

It was only when the voice spoke that Owen realized his mistake. He'd put the specialized earpiece for Dispatch in his right ear that morning, same as always, while the sound was clearly on his left, the spot where he'd stuck the lower-tech team transceiver.

"Titan, this is Galvanize. We're needed."

"What's up?"

"A Hero team, Wild Bucks, squared off against a small gang of Supers about an hour ago. They managed to get them subdued, but there was a significant amount of collateral damage. We just received clearance to enter the area and evacuate any remaining civilians from unstable buildings or rubble. The epicenter of the damage area is at Forty-Third and Quail. Do you need us to pick you up?"

Owen quickly glanced at the nearest sign post; he was crossing through Twenty-First and Morgan. Much of Brewster was laid out in a simple grid fashion, with numbers moving sequentially and letters alphabetically, meaning he was twenty-two blocks up and four blocks over. He'd never had a super-speeder's abilities, but he did have powerful legs and a cardiovascular system that could go for days.

"No, you guys go ahead. I can run there faster."

"Understood. Let me know when you're getting close and I'll give

you directions to meet us. This is a large scale evacuation, so other PEERS teams will be on site assisting, as well as Heroes with appropriate abilities.”

Galvanize didn’t have to spell it out for him: a lot of people would be there, and so would cameras, which meant he’d better make sure to keep on his best behavior. Increased media scrutiny was going to be part of their lives now, at least for a while, and they needed to make it work for them. Like a wild horse, you either held on and rode or fell off and got trampled.

“I’ll seek you out as soon as I arrive.” Owen turned and reoriented himself, pausing long enough to check the traffic. He wouldn’t be moving as fast as a car, but if he accidentally hit one then it wouldn’t make any difference. As important as it was to get to the scene, it was just as important not to hurt anyone on the way there. Not for the first time since he’d re-donned the mask, Owen dearly missed having a teleporter on call.

\* \* \*

Owen’s mouth hung open as he drew closer to the section of city scarred from battle. Even blocks away he could see the wreckage: shattered glass, overturned cars, huge dents in the ground where large objects had clearly struck. No wonder this was a large-scale evacuation; he was only at the fringes and the place looked like hell. The gang they took down must have been incredibly powerful.

“Dispatch, this is Titan.” He didn’t slow down as he spoke, easily hurdling minor obstacles without so much as missing a step.

“Dispatch recognizes Titan.” She was there, ready as always, just waiting for him to say her name.

“I’m meeting my PEERS team and heading to respond to the evacuation caused by some dickhead Supers and Wild Bucks.”

“So they reported in.” Dispatch wasn’t particularly curt with her reply, or even sarcastic. Like nearly everything she said, it was factual and detached. Strangely, it made her one of the easiest people most Heroes had in their lives to talk to.

“I’m getting first sight on the level of destruction and it’s a damn wreck. What were the Class Assessments on the gang they fought?” Owen jogged by the remains of what had probably been a small storefront, but was now so crushed it was impossible to say for sure.

“The Supers that Wild Bucks faced were ranked as follows: one NTC Class and three Standard Class. Abilities were determined to be: one healer, one advanced mind, and two shifters.”

Owen put his foot down so hard with the next step that he accidentally shattered a piece of already broken street. He must have heard her wrong; that was the only viable explanation.

“Dispatch, confirm, did you say an advanced mind and two shifters, all Standard Class, caused this much destruction in their neutralization?”

“Correct.” Her voice held no judgment in its calm, slightly-accented tones, but only because that’s who she was. For someone like Owen, looking at the devastation caused, it was impossible to remain quite so detached.

Owen was getting closer now and beginning notice things like smashed out corners of buildings, ones that had thankfully already been tagged as clear. The big white spray-painted “X” was an easy visual marker, saving him from having to radio in about every leaning structure he came across.

“Dispatch, what was the civilian causality count from this operation?”

“Final tally will not be available until the evacuation is completed.”

“Give me current total.”

“Five confirmed, with three more in critical condition.”

“Thank you, Dispatch.”

Owen nearly panted out those last words, his breath suddenly short for reasons that had nothing to do with physical exertion. Five dead in taking down four Supers who didn’t rate above standard class, not to mention countless dollars in destruction. This wasn’t like with the robots, when everyone was doing the best they could just to neutralize the threat. Three Standards and an NTC, none with particularly rare abilities, should be a breeze for *any* Hero team, regardless of their composition.

Five dead, three hanging on, and God only knew how many people trapped or in danger, waiting to be evacuated. There was no way the DVA wouldn’t be digging into this one, and with good damn reason. Topsy’s team had fucked up royally, and they had to be held accountable for it. As Owen glanced around one more time, surveying the wreckage around him that had once been a neighborhood, he was struck with a single overwhelming

sentiment:

The DVA was going to have to get in line behind him.

That would come later. Right now there were people in danger, innocents who had nothing to do with the situation currently threatening their lives. They mattered more than anything, and it was time to finally start using his powers like a Hero.

Titan put on an extra burst of speed, bearing down on the destroyed area with all the unstoppable of a derailed freight train.

## 32.

Titan found his team just as Galvanize was returning to them from a small cluster of men also wearing masks and capes. The number of unfamiliar uniforms and intensity of the situation made it impossible to determine who was a Hero and who was a corpie, but Titan realized that for the first time, he honestly didn't give a shit about the distinction. Everyone was here to help. That was the only thing that mattered.

"Listen up," Galvanize said, addressing his team with clear, ringing authority. He might be a nice guy, but now was not the time for kindness. Now was the time for straightforward orders and prompt obedience. "Afterthought is currently sweeping for minds of people who are trapped, and Scope is using his senses to find the ones who are unconscious. They're on point for this recovery and directing all efforts, so if they give you an order, you carry it out. Understood?"

Most of the team nodded, except for Titan, who said, "Yes, sir." In another situation, one of the others might have ribbed him a bit for the over-enthusiasm, but now each was focused on receiving his or her assignment.

"Hexcellent, you and Huggles are needed to help open up cars with people stuck inside. Switch to Big Henry if the situation demands it, but when you run low on juice, stay with Huggles. We've got plenty of heavy lifters but a pair of blades is always handy." Galvanize pointed the leather-clad girl toward a group gathering near a flipped food truck, and she took off without a word.

"Bubble Bubble, you're helping with evacuating people from higher floors of unstable buildings. Airborn is coordinating, so go to her and follow her directions. If she finishes her operation, come to me for a new assignment."

"Absolutely," Bubble Bubble replied, moving briskly off toward a nearby woman who was hovering a foot or two from the ground.

"Zone, you're with Titan on rubble-clearing duty, and I'm going to stay with Scope and Afterthought to direct us."

"But--"

“This is not up for discussion,” Galvanize said, eyes hard as he stared at the muscular young man. After a moment, he spoke again, and this time his voice had softened just a touch. “Zone, we need someone who’s on our radio with them so they can tell us where to dig people out. I’ve only got moderate strength, nothing beyond the human spectrum, and no one who is out there needs my enhancing ability. I know you two don’t get along, but right now I don’t care about your feelings. Real people are out there waiting for us, and if we piss away time on petty bullshit, we might not get to them in time. Do we have a problem?”

“No. . . sir.” Zone didn’t break eye contact with Galvanize, but his shoulders dipped and his chest moved inward as he conceded the battle.

“Good. Move to that building immediately,” Galvanize said, pointing to a five-story brick building with a massive hole in the center. “The insides have been severely damaged, and with the breaks in the exterior as well, we’re not sure how long before the whole thing comes crashing down. Zone, you go to the area directly southeast of it; you’ll recognize it by the giant pile of bricks. We’ve got confirmed people in there who need help. Titan, you’re going into the building itself to grab a few people stuck in tight areas. Is it an issue if the building collapses on you?”

“Not for me, but I’d only be able to shield so many people nearby,” Titan said. Depending on the size of the people in question, he could usually handle anywhere between two and four adults, though tending to that many would make getting out with them nearly impossible.

“Okay, I’ll keep your groups small. Get in there and wait for direction. Move quickly. If the building drops, we’re estimating it will hit a lot of nearby workers on the way down, so Crush is going to implode it once it’s evacuated. Don’t be dumb, but don’t dilly-dally either.”

“On it.” Titan headed off toward the building. It felt strangely familiar, drawing close to a place impending collapse. His team might not have spent a lot of time on cleanup, but they made damned sure to clear out everyone put in danger by one of their fights.

The low, simmering anger that Wild Bucks had kindled flared up again. All this damage, and where were those little shits to help? It was possible they’d already been hauled off to DVA questioning, but he doubted it. Powerful as the Department of Variant Human Affairs was, they were still a government agency, and those things were simply not built to run with that much efficiency. No, more likely they were too ashamed to show their faces

at this scene. He hoped Topsy was tearing them a new asshole right now. Despite being the guy they called in when they had to take a “scorched earth” approached to a target, Topsy had always been good about keeping the destruction he caused contained. That was a lesson that needed to get passed on to his trainees, and fast.

Titan came around the corner, walking up to the building to find another man standing there, his head tilted in the way common to one listening to an earpiece. He had to be a shifter; he was wearing a skintight costume made of the telltale shimmery fabric designed to accommodate altered forms. It was useful as hell, invented by some tech-genius before Titan’s time. The material was able to stretch to accommodate all manner of sizes, but it was a pain in the ass to get any sort of stain out of. That probably explained why this guy had opted for a black version. He might be able to get at least a few wears out of a single suit of the stuff.

The man glanced over his shoulder as Titan approached. “You’re the other guy?”

“Didn’t know I was, but it seems like I am.”

“Just got updated with new orders from Scope. I’m supposed to secure the bottom floor as best I can while you go up to the higher ones.”

“I’m a pretty heavy guy,” Titan said. If the interior was that damaged then every pound of difference mattered.

“In my shifted form, my weight is measured in tons.”

“Ground floor for you it is.” Titan stuck out his meaty hand in greeting. “I’m Titan, pleasure to work with you.”

The man in black shiny material laughed, even as he shook Titan’s hand. “I already know who you are. My name is Granite; I’m the strongman from Elemental Fury.”

### 33.

“That a fact? I didn’t recognize you outside your shifted form.” Titan kept a close watch on Granite’s face as they finished the handshake. Teams were complicated entities; in order to function, every member had to be completely loyal to one another. That didn’t mean they had to agree all the time, though. Granite would back Gale in any moves she made against Titan, but that didn’t mean he necessarily harbored any personal animosity toward the older Hero.

“I try not to get photographed in human form, even with the mask. If I can pull it off then retirement will be a lot easier.” Granite released Titan’s hand, his own eyes clearly scrutinizing the other man as well. “Trying to figure out if I dislike you as much as Gale does?”

“Obviously.”

Granite laughed, a deep, booming sound so cheerful that it seemed incongruous against the chaos around them. “Don’t mind Gale. She’s a little tightly wound. In the last few years some high profile Heroes have come out of Brewster, folks who moved up to bigger cities and better merchandising sales. That’s great for them, but the fact that they’ve all come from here means a lot of new or overambitious Heroes have been migrating to our town, trying to use it as a career springboard.”

At last, the pieces of Gale’s behavior fell into place for Titan. When a city had a lot of well-known Heroes coming out of it, it was considered “hot.” Hot cities were a double-edged sword. Not many truly skilled criminal Supers tried to start shit in them for fear of meeting too strong of opposition, but it also drew the sort of Heroes who were desperate to get bigger in the public eye. Those were the Heroes who made dangerous mistakes and took stupid risks, doing things that got innocent people killed. No wonder Gale had been on such a hair trigger about him coming to her town; if she was already dealing with a bunch of upstarts, the last thing she needed was someone with his profile doing the same thing. It would validate their behavior, invigorate them, and lead to even more reckless choices.

“Should I bother telling you that’s not what I’m here to do, or is it wasting my words?” Titan asked.

“I already know that you aren’t in Brewster for anything PR-related,”



Granite assured him. “For one thing, you’re fucking Titan. You were back in the public eye as soon as you put the mask on. For another, Brewster is hot right now, but you don’t need hot. You could have walked into any city in the continental USA and been huge. And lastly, I mean, come on. You’re shepherding a team of corpies around. That is not the action of an overly ambitious man.”

“Glad at least someone on your team believes me.”

“More than you might think. Of course, you know that won’t affect anything.”

“Of course,” Titan said. Whether Granite believed him to be an attention-seeking ass was irrelevant. Gale was going to order her team to come at him hard during the ability assessment, and they would all obey. She was their leader, they were on a team, and short of a severe moral conflict with her orders, they would follow her without question. Titan not only understood that, he respected it completely.

“Titan, stand by for entry. You’ve got a third en route.” Galvanize’s voice crackled over the radio in Titan’s ear, more strained than it had sounded when they’d last spoken.

“Looks like we’re almost clear,” Granite said. He tapped his own ear as he spoke and gave a small nod. “I just got word to shift.”

Without another word, Granite changed; the suitability of his Hero name became immediately apparent. His dark skin altered, growing lighter but with a distinct gray hue. The outfit on his body sprang and stretched as his form expanded, widening and rising in nearly equal measure. An audible crunching sound, like a tumbling bag of rocks, filled the air as his entire body’s composition altered itself.

In the span of ten seconds, Titan went from looking at a muscular young man to a nine-foot-tall monster composed entirely of stone. It towered over him; Titan had to look up to see the thing’s face, a strange sensation for a man his size.

“More familiar?”

“Much,” Titan replied. He’d studied up on all of Gale’s team ever since she put out the possibility of an ability assessment. Granite was large, strong, and durable, which would have effectively classified him as normal strongman in combat, but his transformation also had a handy side-effect.

Granite could reform his stone body easily, even if the individual pieces were shattered. This made him functionally unstoppable by brute means, though he'd previously suffered serious injury at the hands of powerful elementalists. Titan had an idea for how to handle him in the ability assessment, but now that he'd actually met the guy it seemed a cruel method to use.

"Hey you two, ready to go in?"

These words came from a tall, willowy woman who floated over to them. She was adorned in a white and blue costume with a cape that fell nearly to her calves. If she was a Hero, then she was the type who didn't do straightforward combat, because a cape like that would have gotten her killed already. "I'm Aether from Transcendental Justice."

"Granite," the large being of living rock rumbled.

"Titan," Titan said. "Granite is supposed to hold the bottom floor while I go up and grab anyone trapped. What assignment are you on?"

"I'm with you, Titan," Aether replied. "I can make myself and other people or objects incorporeal, so I'm supposed to help you search and handle the delicate extractions."

A wave of relief washed over Titan. He'd been seriously worried about accidentally bringing the building down when trying to get to someone. Having a Hero with a light touch would make the extractions dozens of degrees more effective. Whoever was coordinating this effort had a solid head on their shoulders; they were allocating resources in a way that maximized their usefulness. Corpie or Hero, when this was over, Titan meant to shake that person's hand.

"Scope sent me over with word that we have survivors on the third and fourth floor confirmed, and Afterthought is scanning the fifth floor as we speak. Granite, your orders stay the same. Titan, I'm on point to survey the area as we go, so hang back a few steps behind me. I'll make sure the floors in each section can bear your weight. Once I get you up to the third floor, I'll leave you to extract while I grab people from the fourth. If you hit a situation where you're not sure you can get someone out without knocking things down, just give me a holler. I'll be listening." Despite her lithe frame, Aether's voice was authoritative and certain as she doled out the orders. Whatever role she filled for her team, Titan had a hunch she did it well.

"Sounds good," Granite said.

“Glad to hear it, because we just got clearance,” Aether announced.  
“Let’s get in there and save some people.”

## 34.

Titan stepped through the area that had once been the front door of the apartment building, carefully surveying the landscape as he moved. In a situation like this where the building's stability was in question, someone of his strength could accidentally bring the whole thing down with one misstep. The ground floor was, thankfully, almost completely bare, save for the easy-to-spot support columns. So long as he steered clear of those and load-bearing walls, he should manage to get through this rescue mission without causing some collateral destruction of his own.

There was just enough time for Titan to stop and wonder how Granite was going to get past the small front door before the giant rock-man sauntered calmly through the wall. Aether maintained a gentle but firm grip on his shoulder, releasing her hold once they were completely clear of the entrance. Granite seemed to shimmer for a moment, and the subtle sound of wood groaning beneath his massive feet told everyone he was solid once more.

"Handy. I don't know many density changers who can affect others so easily," Titan said.

"You still don't," Aether replied, floating carefully over to him. "What I do is more akin to shifting us to another plane of existence, one that interacts visually and audibly with ours, but not physically."

"Damn." Titan had been around a long time and had worked with dozens, if not hundreds, of Supers. Aether's ability wasn't wholly unique, but something that powerful was strikingly rare. He'd read up on the local Hero teams, including Transcendental Justice, but if there had been anything especially remarkable about their records, he'd missed it. If a woman with this ability was playing second string then Granite may have understated just how hot Brewster was for Heroes at that moment.

"Damn is right; I am quite incredible," Aether agreed. "Granite, Scope believes the south wall is currently the weakest, so that's where you're needed. Keep your radio on; you may need to change positions as Titan moves around the upper floors."

"Oh great. . . as if I don't get enough of being bossed around from Gale." Granite's words were glib, but he still headed over to fulfill his assignment. Titan understood the reaction; sometimes in stressful situations,

making bad jokes was a small way to combat the sense of seriousness that often felt overwhelming. It was why so many Heroes ended up quipping through a fight: they were trying to mentally push back the terror and violence so they could function.

“Titan, you’re with me on the first few floors. They should be stable, but there’s no reason to risk it unnecessarily.” Aether’s hand landed on his shoulder. There was a light tingling sensation, and for a moment Titan’s stomach lifted as though he were at the crest of a rollercoaster’s tracks. Then, as suddenly as it started, the sensation was gone. He was still firmly standing on the floor.

“That is. . . unexpected,” Aether said. “I didn’t expect you to be a nullifier.”

“I’m not, but I did fight a guy with phasing powers a few decades back. He could trap people in this dark existence without light, sound, or touch for hours at a time. Bastard managed to sneak up and get me on our first encounter.”

“Fascinating, but it doesn’t explain why I can’t phase you.”

“I was getting to that,” Titan said. “Next time I fought him, he got a hand on me and then received the shock of his life when I stayed right there in front of him. The same tricks don’t work on me twice, and I think your power is similar enough to his that my resistance countered it.”

“Can’t you turn it off? What if you need healing?”

“My body handles its own healing, and while I can suppress it if I really need to, it takes real focus so it’s an imprecise process. I don’t think either of us wants me slipping back to solid while suspended in the air,” Titan said.

“A fair point.” Aether floated down to the ground, rippled momentarily, and became solid. “I suppose all we can do is go slowly and let me test the stairs as we move.”

“That was pretty much my plan from the get-go,” Titan replied.

The two set off on the careful climb, checking each of the stairs as they went. Luckily, the building had been constructed in a more industrial era, long before cheap cost-cutting measures had given rise to staircases that were barely anchored at each level. Within five minutes they had passed the first

two floors and made it to the third without incident. The floor there was less solid than on the lower levels, and a part of the back wall had been blown out, allowing them to see the cleanup going on outside.

“This is as high as you can go,” Aether told him. “Everything above is too unstable. Scope and Afterthought finished the scan while we were climbing. I’ve got three targets on floor four and one on floor five. You’ve got two here: one in room one-three-two and one in room four-two-one. Got that?”

“Got it,” Titan might not have had the world’s best memory, but he had long ago mastered the art of quickly memorizing short bursts of information. In the field, it often made the difference between people saved and lives lost.

“Good. As soon as you’ve got both, get them out and get clear. Crush is in position to implode this building the moment we’re done. The sooner we can bring it down, the better for everyone around it.”

“What if you need help with all of yours?”

Aether rolled her eyes in an exaggerated motion. “I can fly through matter, remember? Smart money says I’ll get all four of mine out before you finish your two.”

“Five bucks?”

“Fine. First one to have all their people on the ground, safely outside the building, wins,” Aether said.

The two Heroes shook briefly, then Aether lifted off the ground and floated through the ceiling to the floor above. Titan watched her go, noting the seamless way she phased herself through the various barriers. The woman was clearly hiding some aspects of her abilities, not that Titan blamed her. Even among other Heroes, it was prudent to keep a few bits about one’s power close to the vest. It wasn’t an everyday occurrence, but Heroes did fall from grace. Fighting someone who knew all of your limits and weaknesses was a worst-case scenario for any Hero.

Titan started tentatively down the hallway, listening carefully to the groans of the floor for any signs that something was about to give. In a situation like this, Heroes like Aether definitely had the upper hand. Still, there were people depending on him to get to them, so Titan was determined not to go crashing through the floor.

He hoped.

## 35.

The man in the first apartment was young, single from the looks of the décor, and trapped under a dresser. Titan didn't even bother knocking as he entered; pleasantries were for people with more time and less at stake. He shattered the lock and pushed the door open, revealing a panicked young man pinned under heavy furniture. Extricating him was easy; Titan lifted the dresser as though it had as little substance as a banker's promise. Once the man was free, it became clear that the falling furniture had fractured, if not broken, his leg. This actually made things easier as far as Titan was concerned. Carrying someone was much simpler than trying to have them follow him through an unstable building.

In the second apartment, Titan and his new passenger found a woman whose refrigerator had tumbled over and blocked the door. With a quick call of caution, Titan slowly pressed the thin wooden door open, sending the sizable fridge sliding across the carpeted floor. He'd just finished moving it when a loud cracking sound filled the air, accompanied moments later by a shudder that ran through the entire building. He barely had time to wonder what had happened before Galvanize's voice crackled to life on his radio.

"Titan, Granite just reported that the southern wall came down. From what we can see it's causing a ripple effect that's going to send the whole thing crashing. You need to get your people clear immediately."

"Was Granite trapped under the collapse? Did Aether finish hers yet?" As he spoke, Titan grabbed the recently-freed woman around her midsection and lifted her up, holding her at his left side just as he was holding the man with the broken leg on his right.

"Granite is perfectly fine; it would take more than one wall to encumber him. Aether is above you retrieving her final survivor from floor five. Since she's unaffected by things like falling buildings though, you need to worry about you and yours."

Another shudder rocked the building, this one causing the floor at Titan's feet to buck slightly. The man let out a yelp of terror, while the woman seemed to draw closer to Titan's massive frame.

"Evacuating now. Any guess on how long I've got?"



“I’m watching the western side of the building crumble as we speak. You have no time. Get out of there any way that you can.”

“Was afraid you’d say that,” Titan mumbled. He turned down the hallway and took off at a sprint, no longer concerning himself with the integrity of the floor. If he went through it now then it would just put him closer to the ground, which would make escape easier. As it was, he was already in a time-crunch. If it had just been him then he could have blasted through the walls and crashed to the ground, no problem. Having humans with him complicated matters. They could get seriously injured if he went smashing through bricks. Of course, they were still going to be in harm’s way even with his current plan, but better a few broken bones than a building’s worth of rubble coming down on top of them.

He rounded a corner just as the building gave up a shake so powerful that the walls around them momentarily buckled. It was going to be a close one, but Titan at least had his goal in sight. At the end of this hallway, directly in front of them, was the busted wall that he’d seen when first reaching this floor. Through it, Titan could already see the other rescue workers retreating from the collapsing building. That was good, because he needed a clear landing area. As he reached the end of the hallway, Titan pushed himself off with the tremendous power in his sizable legs, pulling his people in as close as possible.

Titan rocketed out of the side of the collapsing building, hurtling through the air as both of his rescued citizens screamed bloody murder in his arms. He paid them no mind, all his focus on getting his body’s orientation right. The landing was key: it would determine if these two ended the day facing lumps, bruises, and bad memories, or life-threatening injuries. Titan lifted them both, one in each arm, while tilting his legs downward. He needed to absorb as much of the fall’s force as he could with his legs and try to dissipate the rest by letting his arms stay flexible. This was a technique he’d developed many years ago for rapid evacuations, but it had been a very long time since he’d used it.

Dust and rocks flew upward as Titan came smashing down, long legs sliding a bit across the terrain as he tried to bend them upon landing. Once or twice he nearly lost his footing, but old habits and a steely will allowed him to stay upright. When he finally came to stop his charges were shaken, coughing, and clearly scared out of their minds, but alive and relatively unscathed.

“Everybody okay?” Titan asked. Both the man and the woman gave weak but recognizable nods to the affirmative. He’d probably have them checked out by a healer just to be safe; however, for the moment, self-diagnosis would have to suffice.

Behind them, a loud crackling sound filled the air. Titan turned around just in time to see the building he’d just been in collapsing in on itself like a film strip on fast-forward. Dark swirls of energy surrounded it as it fell, and within moments the building was nothing more than a pile of rubble in the center of its former slab. The energy dissipated, and a small-statured man in a black and white costume headed back toward the area where Scope and Afterthought were coordinating things.

“That was pretty cool,” said the man still clutched in Titan’s hand. His voice finally snapped Titan back to the situation. The large Hero lowered his passengers gently to the ground.

“Galvanize, do we have any healers on hand? I’ve got a citizen with a busted leg, and after the day he’s had, a patch-job seems the least we can do.”

“We’ve already got two heading over. You just sit tight and they’ll come to you. Nice job with the exit, by the way.”

“Well, the elevator was out and I just can’t stand the tediousness of stairs.”

“You did good work, plus I’m sure Mr. Greene will be happy that the press was on hand to document your efforts.”

Titan had to bite back the urge to groan out loud. He hadn’t been showboating in the slightest, but once the media started playing the clip of him leaping from the building, Gale was going to be impossible to deal with.

As he ruminated on his poor fortune, Titan noticed Aether floating down a few feet away, a young man holding onto her like she was. . . well, like she was the one keeping him afloat after escaping a collapsing building. Their eyes met as she landed, and Titan flashed her a wide grin.

It might not have been the most graceful exit in the world, but it had won him five bucks.

## 36.

Though Titan's high-flying exit did mark a high point in the rescue efforts, it by no means signaled the end of them. Before the work was considered complete, several more buildings were evacuated, dozens of cars pulled open or moved, and two more unstable structures had to be collapsed. Cleanup would be a whole other ordeal, one that the city's services would have to handle. PEERS and Heroes were willing to pitch in on small scale things downtown, but one glance at the ravaged cityscape made it clear that this was work for professionals.

Despite the many hours it took, Titan was feeling fairly upbeat as they arrived back at the penthouse. They'd managed to save nearly everyone still alive in the rubble, and he'd personally only encountered one person that was already gone. Titan had done his best to get put on the jobs with a high likelihood of encountering a dead body, so the one poor soul represented a surprisingly decent ratio. He didn't, by any stretch of the imagination, enjoy discovering corpses, but he'd been a Hero for a long time. Better he did it than someone who'd never experienced a thing like that. The first time could be traumatic, and was best handled in private, surrounded by teammates and friends. After all his years, Titan could hide the way seeing the bodies affected him; he just couldn't stop their faces from haunting his most terrible dreams.

His team stepped into the penthouse, everyone too worn out, physically and mentally, to bother talking. Instead of finding an empty place to relax in, however, they found Mr. Greene waiting with his arms crossed. Galvanize immediately pulled himself up straight and stepped toward their boss.

"Evening, sir. What can we do for you?"

"Most of you can go take the night to unwind; you did exemplary work this afternoon. Titan, however, needs to have a discussion with me."

"She called, huh?" Owen said. Deep down he'd been hoping Gale's last outburst had been nothing but bluster, even after hearing Granite's reasons for her concerns.

"If by 'she' you mean Gale, the leader of Elemental Fury, then yes 'she' most certainly did. Why, exactly, would you think to agree to a

publicized power assessment without taking it through us first?”

“I knew it! I fucking knew it!” Zone whirled around, all exhaustion suddenly absent from his face. He thrust a long finger mere inches from Owen’s eyeball. “You were just using us to get your profile up, log a little good will, and now you’re trying to jump ship to the most popular team in Brewster. I told Galvanize you’d pull this shit!”

“Calm down there; you can walk to conclusions instead of jumping at them.” Owen greatly disliked having Zone’s finger so close to his face, but if he knocked it away then it would seem like a sign of aggression, and right now he needed to appear as peaceful as possible. “Gale insisted on doing a power assessment on me. I never once asked to join her team, nor did she offer. The woman is almost as suspicious of me as you, thinks I’m here to grand-stand at the expense of doing the job right.”

“So she indicated on the call,” Mr. Greene confirmed. “But that doesn’t explain why you agreed to it without proper clearance, let alone upped the ante to a public event.”

“The event part was my agent trying to call her bluff and get her to call the whole thing off,” Owen said. “I’ll be the first admit, that one sort of backfired on us. As for why I didn’t get clearance. . . why don’t we go to your office for that discussion?”

It was a simple request, one that Owen tried as hard as he could to phrase as a mere bit of propriety. Unfortunately, as he watched Greene’s face and the looks of his team, Owen knew they’d all read it as a power play. They thought he was trying to force Greene off balance and shift the field of battle to his own terms. Of course, this left Greene only one response, which was a damned shame. Owen really hadn’t meant it as some sort of verbal dick-joust, but no one would believe that once he actually answered Greene’s question.

“Right here is fine, Titan, or do you not feel like your team deserves to hear your reasoning?”

Owen shook his head. Damned fool had held his ground and brought team loyalty into this. Greene left his caged Hero only one way out, and it was not a pretty one.

“No, I just thought it would be more respectful to bring this up in private,” Owen replied, keeping his voice as even as he could. “But since you want to go there, right here and now, I’ll tell you why I didn’t get clearance from you: because I don’t need any. I don’t work for you.”

“The pay and accommodations we’re providing tell a very different story.”

“Recheck your contracts. You’re providing all that as part of compensation for the time I spend working *with* you. Heroes aren’t for sale; we’re for rent at best. An active Hero, in fulfillment of his duties, is only beholden to one entity: the people he protects. The Department of Variant Human Affairs is the proxy representative of that group, and they’re the only ones we have to get clearance or permission from to do our jobs. Jobs that, sometimes, include working with other Heroes or teams and doing things like power assessments. You may have sway over how things are handled on a PEERS operation, but I’ll say it again: I don’t need your clearance for anything Hero-related.”

Mr. Greene’s normally composed face was flushed red. Whatever he’d been expecting Owen to offer up, it had not been an open challenge to his authority. He stayed silent for a moment, glaring at the mountain of a man and undoubtedly wishing their physical capacities were reversed.

“I could terminate your contract and have you kicked out of this building faster than you could pack your masks in a makeshift sack.”

Owen was tempted, for the slimmest of moments, to back down and let Greene save some face. Unfortunately, that time had already passed. He’d tried to give Greene an out where they could talk this through peacefully and the manager had rejected it. Owen was a fan of peaceful resolution whenever possible, but if someone was going to push him into a fight, they were going to get everything he had to throw. And Owen Daniels, much like Titan, could throw damn heavy.

“That’s your right as overseer of this team, but what you can’t do is tell me how to do my job. If you can’t square with that, then go sign whatever you have to sign to end this deal. I’ll tell you right now, though: the next Hero you bring on payroll is going to draw the same line that I just did. We fight goddamned monsters and keep innocent people safe; there is no time in our world for anyone to try and impose extra bureaucratic bullshit on that process. I’ll try to keep you in the loop on things, as a *courtesy*, but if you expect me to run and ask permission for what I have to do to fill my role as Hero, then we’re going to have a problem. So, Mr. Greene, do we? Do we have a problem?”

The entire room seemed to hold its breath as Owen and Mr. Greene stared at one another. Either this would end, right here and now, or it would

be allowed to fester in the weeks to come. One thing was certain, though: the relationship between these two men had been fundamentally altered in a way that could never be undone.

“Everyone go to bed and rest,” Mr. Greene said at last. “It was a long, very disturbing day for all of you, and I’m sure we can have cooler discussions once your emotions have calmed.”

Placating as his words were, the ferocity in his eyes as he glared at Owen was unmistakable. He’d been called out in front of his employees, and he’d backed down. Mr. Greene might be willing to let that slide for now, but it was only a matter of time until he made a play to turn the tables.

Owen shook his head and walked toward his room. He seemed to be pissing off everyone he met lately. If he had the self-control, he’d have resolved to just stop talking. Instead, he took a very long shower and tried not to think about all the pitfalls he’d already manage to surround himself with.

## 37.

The first thing Owen did upon waking the next morning was to call Lenny and officially get the ball rolling to set up the power assessment with Gale. Much as a part of him was inclined to hold on to the hope of getting it canceled, after his stand against Greene the night prior, Owen either had to do it or look like he was giving in to what the company wanted. That was a precedent he refused to set, for himself and for any new Hero Liaison that might ultimately get his job when Greene finally decided to toss him out.

The second thing Owen did was try and reach Topsy to talk about the carnage his team had caused, but Topsy proved to be impossible to contact. He didn't pick up his phone or answer e-mail. Even Dispatch couldn't patch their communications together, saying he was registered as inactive for an indefinite period of time. If Dispatch couldn't reach someone, it usually meant they were dead, held prisoner by someone who *really* knew what they were doing, or dealing with the DVA. Given what had happened, Owen's money was on the last option. He'd been in more than one of those meetings himself, and truthfully, he'd probably pick going toe-to-toe with an Armageddon Class over being in another one. All the same, he hoped the DVA was putting the fear of God into those kids, because from the damage he'd seen, they clearly needed it.

With his calls made, Owen suited up in his Titan outfit and headed down to the common area. With the previous night's chaos, he hadn't gotten the chance to see what was on the schedule for the today. He walked in to the kitchen area and found all of his team there eating breakfast. Galvanize took one look at him and gave himself a small thump on the forehead.

"Titan, I'm so sorry. In all the confusion of yesterday I completely forgot to tell you: we're off today. No PEERS team is allowed to work more than six days consecutively, unless there are extenuating circumstances on par with a national emergency. Mordent gives us Sundays totally off: no appearances, no promos, no emergency response work. As Hero Liaison, there's nothing for you to supervise, so I'd assume you're off as well."

"You guys get regular days off? That's a pretty nice perk." Owen was accustomed to the Hero system, where one simply didn't go active or report to Dispatch if they needed a personal day. Most Heroes tried to take them semi-regularly, but it was often very difficult. Each time one went off-duty,

they were left to wonder who their friends and teammates were fighting, if everyone would be there the next day, and if they could have made the difference in keeping someone they cared about alive.

“We’re not machines,” Hexcellent said. “Supers, sure, but we still get tired and worn out. The last thing anyone needs is a PEERS rescue team too tired to do their job well; we’d just be in the fucking way. Probably why the DVA made that rule.”

“If they didn’t, you know Greene would have us running all over the place three hundred and sixty five days a year,” Zone muttered between bites of organic oatmeal.

“I’m sure *Mr.* Greene would use our time wisely, even without oversight from the DVA,” Galvanize said quickly. “However, I know we all enjoy our day off and are grateful to have it. Personally, I’m going to head upstate and visit some friends from college. What does everyone else have planned?”

“Dicking around,” Hexcellent said with a shrug. “Maybe buy some new video games, hit up a comic shop, the usual.”

“I’ve got an audition for a spot on a local commercial,” Bubble Bubble said. She was eating a bowl of what appeared to be fresh strawberries and drinking a cup of green tea, taking each bite with a practiced delicacy.

“You’re not supposed to work,” Galvanize reminded her.

“No, the company cannot *compel* me to work. What I do with my own time is my business. I booked this audition through a non-Mordent representative and Mr. Greene approved the role as image-acceptable.”

“I guess that’s fine then.” Galvanize didn’t look particularly fine with it, but without a point to actually object to, he seemed resolved to not starting a fight. “How about you, Zone?”

“Gym, training, then maybe heading down to the lake,” Zone replied. “My cousin’s renting a house out there and says it’s a good place to relax. Plus, why bother having a body like this if I’m not going to show it off?” Zone accentuated his point by lifting his arm and flexing his bicep, which was indeed large and well-defined.

“Try to behave yourself. After the last pregnancy scare you know Mr. Greene is keeping abreast of your extracurricular activities,” Galvanize



cautioned. Zone gave a half-hearted nod and went back to eating his oatmeal, so Galvanize turned to the final member of the team.

“How about you, Titan? I know you’re new in town, but is there anything you think you’ll do with your day off?”

“You’re welcome to tag along with me,” Hexcellent offered. “You know I hate carrying shit, and Big Henry isn’t exactly crowd friendly.”

“Much as I appreciate it, I think I’ll have to decline,” Owen said. “If I have a day off I should probably use it trying to dig into what’s been discovered about those robots attacks.”

“That sounds more like a day working a side-job than a day off,” Galvanize told him.

“Heroes are generally shitty at taking days off. We’re the type of people who need to be up in the action constantly, otherwise we wouldn’t have chosen this sort of career.” Owen left out the other aspects of it: the guilt, the fear, the constant unease. At least when a Hero was doing something, they felt there was a certain amount of control. After taking a decade off, Owen wasn’t really itching to get back to a life of leisure.

“Try and rest a little bit, if you can,” Galvanize said. “I know physically you’re always in tip-top shape, but mental health is important too.”

“Oh, don’t worry about that. See, I don’t have any real resources for research, which means I’m going to have to bum information off other Heroes. Since I don’t really know any here, at least none that don’t actively distrust me, there’s only one way for me to make those connections and get that info.”

“You going to tease us with this shit all morning or you going to tell us what mysterious Hero technique you’re going to employ?” Hexcellent asked.

“Nothing fancy or mysterious. I’m gathering information the same way people have been doing it for centuries,” Owen said. “I’m going to a bar.”

## 38.

A rookie Hero might have been surprised by the amount of people in Brin's Gate despite the early afternoon hour, but Owen had been around enough to know that Heroes didn't live on set schedules like people working normal jobs. They worked as needed, slept when they could, and took time to socialize whenever they could manage to find the opportunity. To someone who worked a nine-to-five, the idea of having beers with friends at one in the afternoon was scandalous, but to a team coming off a twenty-hour patrol shift, it was a chance to unwind.

The bartender greeted Owen's entrance with a familiar nod. Even having only come in once before, having Gale vouch for him had effectively set up Owen as a known customer, and that meant he'd be able to get real drinks and service. When he was younger he'd worried about going to the bars where Heroes congregated unmasked; after all, what if someone managed to get hold of the staff and torture out information? That was when his mentor explained that these establishments tended to be owned and run by former Heroes, people who weren't quite so easy to coerce. Even with that, there was still a certain amount of risk, but it was one most Heroes made peace with. No one could be the job full-time. Owen had learned early on that if you didn't make time for the person under the mask then both identities quickly burned away.

Owen got a beer, dropping a few bills on the counter to pay for it. These places didn't take cards or checks: too easy to create a paper trail of clientele. It was cash-only, though some establishments let the more trusted and frequent patrons run tabs. He leaned back against the bar and scanned the room, taking note of each patron.

In one corner was a group of four people leaning in and talking in hushed voices. A team no doubt, and probably discussing some matter they should have dealt with at their base. Against the far wall was another cluster of people, this one so large it needed two tables to seat everyone. This group was laughing and seemed to be enjoying themselves. Owen guessed they were either all old friends who had met up or a group that just finished a successful team collaboration. Either way, he wasn't likely to find anyone in there he could talk to.

His best bet was a solo drinker, someone who wasn't already

encompassed by the shell of a conversation. At the bar were two such people. One sat near Owen nursing a glass of scotch, while the other sat several stools down sipping on some light blue cocktail. Scotch was an older man, face a bit haggard and eyes a touch sunken. He was a man who'd been in the life for a long while, and it had taken its toll on him. Cocktail was male too, but he was younger, with a bit of cheer still shining through as he texted on his phone. It seemed a good bet that Scotch was here just to drink, while Cocktail was waiting for people to join him.

Owen took his time deciding which one to approach. Scotch would be skilled and smart, not to mention open about sharing resources with a fellow Hero. The problem was, Scotch had the look of a man who'd seen too much, and wasn't eager to get any more action than he had to. That meant he probably wasn't proactive; more likely he just took calls from Dispatch and did his job. While Scotch was probably the better overall resource, Cocktail still had vigor and optimism. That would make him a better connection to have in the long-term.

"Mind if I ask what you're drinking?" Owen said, sliding a few seats down the bar. "I don't recall the last time I saw that shade of blue in anything non-toxic."

"This might still qualify as toxic; it's got enough alcohol in it to turn me flammable," Cocktail replied. "It's called an Adios Mother Fucker, basically a Long Island except you add Blue Curacao, switch the Coke for Sprite, and double up on all the booze measurements."

"Damn, sounds like somebody named that thing well. I admire your courage putting that in your body."

"I'm heartier than I look," Cocktail replied. That was probably saying quite a bit, because he looked hearty to begin with. Every Hero worked out constantly—that part of HCP training was never forgotten—but even by Hero standards Cocktail had a wide set of shoulders and well-defined arms. He struck one of them out to shake Owen's hand. "Name's Jeremiah."

"Real name? You're a trusting fellow."

"No, Jeremiah is my code name. Long story."

"Aren't they all?" Owen chuckled. He reached over and took the younger man's hand, giving it a gentle but firm shake. "Pleasure to meet you. I'm Titan."

Jeremiah's eyes went wide, but thankfully he didn't jerk his hand away or recoil. Instead, his smile deepened and he stared at Owen more carefully, clearly trying to imagine the man before him in costume. "I'd heard scuttlebutt that you were back in the life and setting up shop in Brewster no less, but I didn't really believe it." They finished shaking hands and Jeremiah picked up his cocktail again. "Then again, that's assuming you're really him."

"I'd offer to lift something heavy, but I just started coming to this bar and I'd rather not piss off the owner. Besides, who would really want to fake being Titan?"

"Someone trying to scare the crap out of villains, probably. Or trying to win respect. But I'm inclined to believe you; you definitely have the stature of Titan. Pair that with the rumors, it seems to add up nicely. Tell me something: are you really running around with a group of corpies these days? I assumed that part had to be people making shit up."

Owen resisted the urge to tell Jeremiah that the official term was PEERS; he needed to stay on his new friend's good side if he wanted to start asking for favors and information so soon. "That part is completely true. They're all good kids, doing the best they can to give back, and I'm enjoying working with them."

"Of course you are." Jeremiah took a long draw from the glass of blue liquid. His voice had been somewhere between sincere and mocking, just between the two enough that it was impossible to pin down which had been intentional. "Tell me, Titan, what brings you out today?"

"Can't a man want a beer?"

"Certainly, but that's not why you're here. You cased the room as soon as you walked in, then spent two and half minutes debating whether to approach me or the other gentleman down there. Now you're trying to ingratiate yourself to me. Obviously you're either after new friends, teammates, or information; I just thought I'd save us some time and cut to the quick of it."

Owen looked the man over once more, with newfound respect. "Telepath?"

"Not even a little bit. Let's just say I majored in one of the less respectable options for people in our careers."

Owen didn't need any more than that: Jeremiah was a Subtlety Hero.

That explained the keen observational skills. They were the Heroes who focused on code cracking, information gathering, and certain unsavory activities that were necessary for Heroes, but not quite as respectable or flashy as punching out a bank-robber. Many Heroes treated those who focused in Subtlety as inherently untrustworthy, at least until they'd been around long enough to see what the Subtlety Heroes brought to the table. To Owen, however, this was the best possible profession for his new acquaintance to have. Subtlety Heroes were all about information, and that was exactly what he'd come out looking for.

“How about I buy you another one of those blue drinks, and you tell me what you know about robots?”

### 39.

“By my count, we’re up to number five,” Jeremiah said after slowly draining a portion of his bright blue drink. “Of course, that’s a bit of speculation; whoever this is certainly doesn’t have monopoly on robots. But going by style and evolution of their design, it seems safe to say we just put down the fifth generation.”

Owen nodded and took a sip of his own beer. “Seeing as that’s hardly common knowledge around town, I’m guessing the others were easier to beat?”

“The first few were, but the fourth generation gave us a bit of trouble. That’s why some of us started doing the research and keeping a log of when these showed up. Each time is always the same: robots show up, cause enough destruction or disturbance to draw out some Heroes, then go to town on them. For those of us with some wits and experience, it’s not a giant issue, but this time they got hold of a team of rookies. That upped the collateral damage considerably.”

“From what I saw yesterday, Wild Bucks going down early in the fight may have been the best thing for everyone,” Owen said.

“Maybe so, but it made the rest of us a lot more cautious. These things were a big leap ahead from generation four. Learning as they fought was bad enough; add in the healing abilities and you get a bot that can catch even a seasoned Hero off guard.”

“Five generations, all with no other goals than fighting Heroes. Has to be a refinement game then,” Owen said. It might be a criminal organization training new members or tech-geniuses testing out designs; either way, there was no shortage of people who used Heroes to refine their abilities. It was a dangerous game to play; every asset lost could put Heroes closer to the main inventor or organization. The flip side was that such a trial-by-fire method could significantly increase the power and knowledge of those pulling the strings.

“That’s what we’re hoping,” Jeremiah said. “The other option is that someone is trying to get enough information on how each Hero in Brewster fights so that they can try and do a purge.”

“In a town this hot? They’d have to be more than crazy, they’d have to be stupid, and whoever built those things is far from stupid.” Owen had only personally witnessed one attempted purge in his lifetime: a coordinated effort by nearly every criminal, Super or mundane, to simultaneously kill off all the Heroes in their city. That had been when he was starting out, fresh off his internship, in a city smaller than Brewster where The Gentle Hammers were one of only three Super teams. To their credit, the criminals had been smart, prepared, and well-coordinated. What they hadn’t been, however, was counting on the new team to be as unstoppable as they were. The effort was foiled, though each of the other teams lost people in the process. It had been a hard, bloody introduction to the world of Heroes, one that Titan had never forgotten.

“There are all different kinds of smart. I’ve got a cousin that can’t remember what he had for breakfast but can quote Tolstoy without missing a beat. Building a robot doesn’t mean someone can’t overestimate their own chances at taking down Heroes.”

“But you don’t think it’s likely,” Owen replied.

“Hell no. Shit, with all the upstarts in this town, not even I can keep track of the Heroes flowing through, and half my damn job is information,” Jeremiah said. Owen doubted the truth of the statement; most Subtlety Heroes tended to undersell themselves when dealing with those they didn’t completely trust. It was one of the many ways they stayed a step ahead of everyone outside their team. “Anyway, if this bot-maker is aiming for a purge, they’ll need a lot more generations to make it viable. Once Elemental Fury took command, the Heroes put those little fucks down hard.”

“Speaking of Elemental Fury, what team do you work for, Jeremiah?”

“Not one that a Hero like you would be familiar with, just a small collective of like-minded Heroes who operate under the name Modus Operandi. Nothing too fancy or flashy; we never even make the top lists of popular Hero teams.”

“Modus Operandi. . . isn’t that the team composed entirely of Subtlety Heroes?”

Jeremiah tilted his head ever-so-slightly and looked at his drinking buddy with new respect. “You actually did enough research to know about us? I’m genuinely impressed. Every story I’ve heard paints you as a sheer brute with little mind to speak of.”

“Gee, what a compliment,” Owen sighed. “I swear, just because I can throw tanks people assume I’m a muscle-headed idiot. I researched most of the Hero teams after I met with Gale; the last thing I wanted to do was rub anyone else the wrong way and end up dealing with unnecessary problems.”

“From what I hear about your upcoming power assessment, you did a fairly shitty job of that.”

Owen shot Jeremiah a hard glance, but he just shrugged and drank more blue liquid. Jeremiah was a Subtlety Hero, after all; it was essentially his job to be plugged in to every outlet of information he could. New Heroes in town, and any friction they might be causing, would certainly be part of that.

“Well, in a few days you’ll get to see firsthand just how bad I am at handling these kinds of situations. The assessment is officially scheduled and set up so that everyone who wants to can see it. Makes me miss the days when all people did was try and kill me in my sleep.”

“Worried you’ll get trounced?”

“Nope, other direction.”

“Ah, a man who at least believes he lives up to his legend,” Jeremiah polished off his drink and motioned to the bartender for another. “Look, don’t fret about it too much. Elemental Fury is a legacy team with outstanding stats and a reputation that deserves respect. That said, we all know Gale has a bit of a stick up her ass. No one is going to hold it against you if you manage to knock her down a few pegs. Well, no one aside from Gale, I mean.”

“Maybe not, but this wasn’t really how I wanted to come back on to the Hero scene.”

“From what I know about you, you sure as hell didn’t leave Hero work under the circumstances you would have chosen; I don’t see why your return should be any different.”

“Has anyone told you that you’re terrible at cheering people up?” Owen asked.

“Chin up, Titan. What I’m saying is you’re disgraced and tons of people hate you. You’re already in the shitpile. So what’s the worst that can happen here? Some people like what you do, some hate it, either way nothing really changes. That’s the upside of being disgraced and hated: you’ve got



more freedom than the rest of us. You're the only one who can truly say and do what he wants without fear of image repercussions. You're free, Titan. Stop moping about and enjoy it, for fuck's sake."

## 40.

The next week was a tame one; Mr. Greene kept his distance as Owen continued to get more familiar with his team. They weren't called on any rescue jobs, which struck Owen as a touch odd when he watched the news and saw what was happening the city, but it wasn't his place to push on that front. After the lines he'd aggressively drawn with Greene in their fight, he didn't have any right to go stepping into the other man's territory.

When Owen woke up on Wednesday, however, it was not with any questions about what the day held in store. This was the day of his power assessment. The details had been finalized on Monday; he was going to Elemental Fury's base at noon (the symbolism wasn't lost on him one bit) to be formally tested by the Hero team. There would be an almost-live feed of the event (slightly delayed in case someone said something unHerolike or a mask came lose and censoring was needed) fed to every person who had purchased the pay-per-view. From what Lenny had told Owen the day before, that was quite a large number of people. On the plus side, when all this was over, Owen would be getting a considerable sum of money no matter how it played out. If he could still get drunk, he likely would have put every cent toward enough whiskey to wash away the memory of the whole ordeal.

Owen suited up in his Titan gear that morning. There was no need to lie about and pretend this wouldn't dominate his day. He was officially off the clock as a Hero Liaison until Thursday, leaving him the whole morning to worry about the fallout from this test. Owen shook it off as he slipped on his mask and pressed the button to activate his earpiece.

"Titan, reporting in."

"Dispatch recognizes Titan. You are shown as inactive today for a power assessment with Elemental Fury. Do you wish to change this status?"

For a moment, Owen was tempted to do just that. If he went active in the morning, it might give him the chance to clear his head and work off some nerves. Best case scenario, if he got pinned down in something big, it could give him a valid reason to skip the assessment altogether. Sadly, tempting as it was, he had to decline the option. Someone in trouble deserved a Hero with their head in the game, and even if he did postpone the assessment, it just meant more time to dread the damn thing. Better to meet it head on and be

done.

“No, that status is accurate,” Owen replied, just a touch of regret in his voice. “Checking in to see if there have been any more robot attacks, ones that the news might not have covered.”

“None so far.” Dispatch didn’t have to specify things like “that I know of” or any such nonsense. If Dispatch didn’t know of it, then it hadn’t happened. “In the current suspected pattern there are several weeks between attacks.”

“I know, just making sure,” Owen sighed. Jeremiah had given him wonderful intelligence, more than Owen could have rightfully asked for, but it didn’t change the fact that he still had no idea what to do next. Nothing frustrated Owen more than being aware of a problem but not being able to deal with it. He was a physical man; he liked to be in the thick of trouble rather than standing around with his thumb up his ass.

“There’s little need to bother checking in. You’ve been moved to priority response when their next attack occurs.”

This was news to Owen, and it showed on his face. Not that Dispatch could tell. Actually, given how much she knew, Owen really couldn’t be sure that she didn’t have some way to watch him when they talked. Priority on a response was which Heroes were tapped first, something he didn’t technically have the right to. For general incidents they went with whoever was closest, but sometimes certain Heroes were tracking a case or had a proven track record against a threat, and it made the most sense to call them in first.

“Who moved me to priority?”

“Unfortunately I am not at liberty to release that information,” Dispatch told him.

Now that was something interesting. Plenty of Heroes had worked their way up to get some say in priority management, but very few had the sort of clearance to move people around without it being on official record. That spoke to someone who was deeply connected, probably with ties to the DVA. With all the noise Owen had been making about his interest in the robots, it was going to be tough to figure out just who had shuffled him into the queue.

“Thanks for letting me know. Even if I’m off the comm, please try to reach me for that. I really want a crack at those things.”

“Of course. I will follow priority protocol as required,” Dispatch said. “Do you have anything else you wish to ask about?”

“No, guess I may as well grab breakfast before my damn assessment.”

“There is no need to worry. Assessments are safe, carefully monitored procedures.”

“Mine’s a bit different than most,” Owen said.

“I’m fully aware of that; yours comes with political ramifications in the Hero field. May I offer some advice to your predicament?”

“By all means, I’d love to hear what you have to say.”

“Be polite, be careful, and be gracious in either victory or defeat.”

It was exactly in line with what Owen had expected her to say. That was Dispatch: always detached, always appropriate, always controlled.

Except. . . she wasn’t quite done talking yet.

“Also, make sure to really kick some ass.”

Owen nearly dropped one of the gloves he’d been slipping over his sizable hands in surprise.

“Beg pardon?”

“You heard me. Titan has been more myth than man for many years now, but some of us remember who you used to be. We’ve been waiting for you to come back to us. Don’t make your first true performance a lackluster affair. The world still needs a Titan. Remind everyone who’s forgotten exactly why that is.”

“I. . . um. . . yeah. Yes.” Titan felt his resolve strengthen. She was right. He hadn’t come back to this world to play politics or patty-cake with an insecure Hero. He’d come back to make a difference, to ensure that every time a criminal said his name they used the same terrified whisper that children used to ask who was there in a dark room. The more scared of him they were, the more often they surrendered, the less people got hurt. It was Heroing 101, and it was time to remind people why entire gangs would once throw down their weapons at the mere mention of the name Titan.

“Thanks, Dispatch.”

“I have no idea what you’re referring to. It is merely my duty to relay

all relevant information as needed.” There might have been a touch of snarkiness in her voice, but with Dispatch it was nearly impossible to tell. That was okay, though. She’d already given him enough for today.

## 41.

When Owen emerged from his room, he found the rest of his team already waiting in the kitchen, clustered together near the breakfast table. Zone looked grumpy and Bubble Bubble seemed bored. Owen barely had time to register their presence before a wave of tantalizing scents hit him at the same time they realized he was there.

“Surprise!” Galvanize announced. “We made you a good luck breakfast.”

The scent was becoming more defined now, and as it sank in Owen realized it was both familiar and delicious.

“Is that. . . did you all make actual waffles and bacon?” The rumble from his stomach nearly overshadowed Owen’s words. Aside from a few hastily grabbed meals from street vendors, he’d been eating at the penthouse since arriving in Brewster, and each of those meals had been a balanced blend of nutrition and terrible.

“Snuck in the ingredients myself,” Hexcellent said, a not-small amount of pride in her voice. “We’re still eating the usual stuff—God knows Greene will shit a kitten if we gain an ounce. But we thought you deserved a real meal before your throw down.”

“I envy your ability to put down such food and retain such a svelte figure,” Bubble Bubble said. From her, it was about as involved and nice a compliment as he could expect.

“Wow. I, um, I didn’t expect this. Thanks. All of you. I mean it.” Sometimes Owen hated his difficulty expressing emotions. It wasn’t like it came from some macho complex; his damned tongue just went dumb when he got overwhelmed by sentiment. When his sons were born, he’d barely been able to string three words together.

“We wanted you to know we support you, as a member of our team,” Galvanize said. If there was any guile or subterfuge in his words, it was too well-hidden for Owen to sense. No, this was just the sort of thing that Galvanize did, because he was a good man and a damned fine leader. Owen found himself thinking that if only the young PEERS had been born with a better ability, he would have made a fine Hero.

“I appreciate i-” Owen was cut off by another rumble from his stomach; this one actually managed to overtake his words.

“We get it, you’re thankful. Now come eat before the offices downstairs start complaining about the noise,” Hexcellent instructed him.

Owen did just that, walking into the kitchen and piling up a plate of lopsided waffles and slightly overdone bacon. Good as their intentions were, the fact remained that none of them had much experience cooking this kind of food. Not that Owen said a word about it; he was so touched by the gesture that everything could have been burned to charcoal and he’d have devoured each bite with gusto.

“Tell us about what this trial of yours involves,” Hexcellent demanded once they were all seated at the table. “Us little shits have never gone through such high and mighty rituals.”

“Be thankful; they’re just overgrown pissing contests that the DVA sanctions.” Owen shook his head even as he stuffed it with a mouthful of waffle. They’d brought in legitimate syrup to go with it, the kind that was more sugar than substance. It was perfect. “Basically, they’ll be testing the various aspects of my ability using their own team. Technically this is to get a sense of what I’m capable of handling, but a lot of times Heroes use it as a chance to prove they’re better than someone else.”

“Heroes acting like dicks, imagine that,” Zone muttered as he stirred around his bowl of gray-looking oatmeal.

“What kinds of tests will they be doing?” Galvanize asked, quickly skating over Zone’s comment.

“Offense, defense, and adaptability,” Owen explained. “The first two are straightforward: they just see what you can dish out and what you can withstand. Supers have too much variety of powers to try and break it down more granularly than that. Usually they’ll have you square off against someone who’s strong in what you’re trying to break. So for offense, they’ll put me against Granite, to see if I’m able to crack him. For defense, I’ll probably have to deal with some of Gale’s most powerful attacks.”

“You said there was a third one, too,” Bubble Bubble pointed out.

“Yeah, that one is the fucker.” Owen barely stifled the urge to let out a frustrated sigh. “Adaptability is where they hand you a hypothetical scenario and see how you deal with it. Shit like ‘you have five minutes to defeat a

teleporter before he successfully sets a bomb off' or 'there are two citizens in the building behind you and a rock elemental is attacking your team.' The one condition is they obviously can't be tests that require lethal force to solve, because the people doing the testing will be playing the villains. Even in a power assessment, killing is pretty strongly frowned upon."

"Damn, that does seem like a bitch," Hexcellent agreed. "Any clue what Elemental Fury will throw at you?"

"At this point, I think they'll go with a classic: the ambush. I'm doing basic patrol and a gang of criminal Supers jumps out and tries to bring me down. It's not fancy, but it lets them use every member of their team against me at once, and since I don't have any travel powers, I'll have to fight each of them to surrender." Owen took a bite of the overly crispy bacon, which helped calm his nerves a touch.

"Given the nature of your abilities, it seems like that would actually favor you," Bubble Bubble pointed out. "After all, you are renowned for your indestructability."

"That's exactly why I think they'll pick it," Owen explained. "It lets them get every one of their people in play, and they can fight me on what's supposed to be my home turf. If they can beat me on that count, it will say a whole hell of a lot about their skill. If they fail, then they have the deniability of it only being because my power is so strong. Besides, there are more ways to incapacitate someone than just by knocking them unconscious."

"Well, whatever they pull, we'll be there to see it," Galvanize said. "We've all been given the afternoon off to watch your assessment."

"Greene was okay with this?"

"Mr. Greene insisted, actually," Galvanize told him. "He sees the benefits in showing a united front and cheering one of our team members on to victory."

Greene was smart; Owen had to give him that. No matter how much he might dislike Titan at the moment, the fact still remained that tying the team to his image was good for the brand. The man could put business over personal feelings, a skill that made him especially dangerous. Regardless of the reason why they'd gotten permission, Owen was glad to have his team at the assessment. It would be nice to have a few people cheering for him.

Especially since they might be the only ones.





## 42.

Unlike the PEERS team, Elemental Fury didn't have the luxury of living in the middle of a high-rise. No real Hero team could ever have gotten away with such a location for a base. Aside from defense concerns, of which there would be plenty, putting a base in a shared building broke one of the core tenants that Heroes lived by: it endangered civilians. It took a special breed of stupid to try and hit Heroes where they lived, but unfortunately, stupid was never in short enough supply. When the attacks came, there would be collateral damage, and that meant anywhere that a Hero laid his or her head had to be as isolated as possible.

When Owen first saw Elemental Fury's base, he was surprised that they'd taken such an old-school approach. Their base was located in the middle of a sizable lake, built atop an island that was almost certainly crafted by some skilled Super. It was several stories high with ample cameras in view; Owen could only imagine the arsenal housed within that wasn't so easy to spot. He spent a while marveling at the place until he remembered that they were a legacy team: the base had been passed down with the title. With a legacy team there would have been at least a dozen Heroes, each with their own skills and connections, who had contributed to the defenses over the years.

For today, a metal walkway ran from the edge of the lake all the way to the base's front door; a few folks in capes and masks were currently making their way across. Owen headed over to the walkway with his team trailing several steps behind. Though they'd come to offer support, they also understood his need to focus before the actual brawling began.

As Owen drew close to the walkway, he spotted a familiar form and felt an unexpected sense of relief wash over him.

"Lenny, it's good to see you." The massive Hero shook hands with the small, round agent. "I thought you might still be pissed about me accidentally pushing Gale into this."

"Come on, now, why would I ever be mad about that? You know I get a cut from your end of the profits, and have you even seen the pre-order numbers? I could take a month-long vacation on one of those islands where they carry you around everywhere."

“Except you don’t take vacations,” Owen pointed out.

“That’s no reason to ruin my fantasy,” Lenny said.

The rest of the team caught up to Owen and Lenny, most of them looking at the bald man speaking confidently to Titan with blatant curiosity.

“You must be my client’s team,” Lenny said, piping up before any of them had the chance to. “Great job you’ve all been doing keeping him in line. Galvanize, loved the way you played on camera at that last rescue. Bubble Bubble, that recent magazine spread was fantastic; wouldn’t be surprised if they call you for a centerfold gig. Zone, congratulations on the new Punch Juice commercial, I hear it’s testing fantastic in the Asian markets. Hexcellent, don’t be surprised if a new makeup company tries to open negotiations with you next week. Word on the grapevine is that you’re turning into a hot commodity and a lot of folks are interested.”

Lenny paused for a moment as the four momentarily-dumbstruck Supers stared at him. “Oh, my apologies. I’m Lenny, Titan’s agent.”

“You certainly are. . . thorough with your knowledge,” Galvanize said, finally managing to find his words.

“It’s my job, my passion, and my pleasure,” Lenny replied. “Why don’t you four go on ahead while I take my boy over to the assessment area? He’s never been here and gets lost easily. The people working the door know to show you to my viewing area; funny how no one noticed I worked VIP seats for myself into the contracts they signed.”

“There’s really no need-” Galvanize began, trying to protest.

“Nope, none of that. You’re with one of mine then you’re with me. Hustle along, now; if I don’t deliver this meathead on time everyone has to wait for the show.”

With little choice and no idea how to protest, the PEERS team headed down the walkway towards the entrance. Hexcellent paused to glance back and throw Owen a “Rock On” hand signal, which he chose to believe was her version of a thumbs up for luck.

“Nice kids,” Lenny said once they were gone. “Sure you wanted to bring them along for this?”

“They demanded to come. Said we were a team and they were going to cheer for me.”

“That a fact?” Lenny glanced up at his old friend. “Still having that trouble with thinking they’re not as good as you?”

“No. I think that problem is good and dead.”

“Fantastic. Now that you’ve found your humility, let’s go remind everyone else why you actually *are* better than them.”

\* \* \*

When Owen emerged from the elevator adjacent to the training arena, he wasn’t surprised to find the entire Elemental Fury team waiting for him. Though the walls were solid, with no windows in sight, he could still feel the familiar tingle of eyes upon him: cameras embedded all over the place, no doubt, picking up everything he said or did. No movement would go unseen, no gesture unrecorded. He was under the public eye once more, and the pressure from their scrutiny was like a dull pain jamming into the back of his head. Much as he loved Hero work, he’d managed to forget how much he hated this part.

“Welcome to our training grounds, Titan.” Gale’s voice was loud, well-enunciated, and authoritative. She’d clearly had ample experience playing to the crowds and cameras. It was no surprise; being the leader, the face, of a team this popular demanded some theatrical skills. “You are here for a standard power assessment, to determine your skill levels in case we should ever need to call upon you for assistance or a team up.”

“Yeah. Sure. That’s exactly why I’m here.” There was no attempt to disguise the biting sarcasm in his tone. Lenny was going to give him shit for this, and honestly, at this point Owen didn’t care. They might have corralled him into this situation, but they couldn’t make him dance like a good puppet.

“Excellent.” If Gale was flustered by his response, she kept it completely off her face. The woman was a pro, no question about it. “Let me introduce you to our team. You’ve already met Granite, I believe.”

Granite was in rock-monster form, but he gave Owen a small wave that seemed out of character for such an intimidating being. It was a nice reminder that not everyone on the team hated him.

“To his right is Spring and Birdsman,” Gale continued.

An older man wearing a costume that looked oddly arcane gave a bow, as did the lean young woman next to him. She wore a tight costume of bright

greens and yellows, although there was a silver sash wrapped around her chest that didn't quite match the motif.

“And on my left you will find Misdirection.”

It was hard to tell if Misdirection was male or female; the flowing costume was topped off by loose black sack of a mask that obscured any details about his or her head. Thankfully, Misdirection actually spoke a greeting instead of bowing.

“A joy to meet you,” said a distinctly female voice from within the hood.

“Same here,” Owen replied. “I’ve heard great things about your entire team, and I have nothing but respect for what you’ve accomplished.” That part he was able to say with sincerity. Stupid politics aside, these people saved a lot of lives, and that was always going to be worth admiration.

“As do we you,” Gale said. “Now that introductions are done, shall we commence the assessment?”

“This is your party; just tell me where you want me to dance.”

“Of course. Let’s keep it standard and start with offense. Granite will serve as your sparring partner.”

Owen nodded and headed into the center of the training arena. So far it was going like he’d expected, but it was unlikely that would continue. In real battle nothing ever kept to plan. All he could hope for was that he’d be able to roll with the changes, and the punches, as they came.

## 43.

As Owen and Granite got situated in the center of the room, the others moved behind a clear barrier that had been erected in one of the corners. While each was probably capable of handling themselves in case of danger, there was no need to take silly chances. After all, when two strongmen went after each other, there was bound to be some shrapnel and collateral damage.

“Listen, before we get started: you’re basically invulnerable to raw force attacks, right?” Owen whispered. The censors should bleep out any discussion of power weaknesses in the video feed, just as they would an identity slip, but it never hurt to be extra cautious with this sort of information.

“Worried you won’t be able to hurt me?” Granite asked.

“No, I’m trying to make sure I won’t accidentally kill you.” There was no taunting in Owen’s voice, no signs of trash-talking. He was being as sincere as he could possibly be, because if Granite was hiding a secret weakness this minor annoyance could turn tragic all too quickly.

The rocky face stared at him for a long moment, reading the big man’s intentions. When he spoke again, it was in a softer voice. “If you’re just throwing punches and kicks I’ll be fine. Breaking the rocks apart, even turning them to dust, that doesn’t stop me from regenerating. As long as you’re not hiding a way to actually destroy them, I can take whatever you dish out.”

“Thanks. That’s a big relief.” Owen still couldn’t exactly run wild in an enclosed space like this, but now he wouldn’t have to be extra dainty. Given the size and density of Granite, he wasn’t sure he could have pulled that off in the first place.

“Whenever you’re both ready, the room is clear,” Gale called from her corner. Ostensibly it was her letting them know they were safe to proceed, but in reality it was her way of telling them to get the damn show on the road.

“You good to go?” Granite asked.

“Ready when you are,” Owen confirmed.

Granite gave a nod, then stood up tall and began to speak to those

watching on the other end of the cameras.

“We will now commence the offense portion of the power assessment. Titan’s goal is to break through my durable body as much as possible, incapacitating me if he’s able. This portion of the assessment will be timed, lasting only two minutes. Since this is purely testing his destructive potential, I will not be fighting back. If, at any point, I feel I am in genuine danger, I am allowed to call ‘stop’ and the assessment will be halted. Titan, are you ready?”

“Hell yes,” Titan replied, giving his knuckles a good cracking for emphasis. A little showmanship wouldn’t be such a bad idea here and there.

“Then let the assessment begin!”

The words were scarcely out of Granite’s mouth when Titan’s first punch connected. It was a straightforward jab to the massive slab of rock that constituted Granite’s torso. There was barely time to register what had happened before the several tons of stone that composed Granite’s body were hurled backward, slamming into the wall with enough force to crack both it and Granite.

“Holy shit,” Spring said, eyes widening as one of the strongest, heaviest Supers she knew got chunked across the room. “That’s a hell of a punch.”

“We’ve always known Titan was strong,” Gale replied, working hard to keep her tone neutral. “It’s part of what he’s renowned for.”

“Still. . .”

As she spoke, Titan walked over to the wall where Granite was pulling himself back to a standing position. The big stone man had barely gotten to his feet before he felt another blow to his torso. He was pinned against the wall as Titan drove his fingers forward, burrowing each digit into Granite’s chest.

“This doesn’t hurt you, right?” Titan asked.

“It doesn’t feel like a fucking Thai massage.” Granite winced, more at the language than discomfort. Even though it would be bleeped, the bleep would still be there, and Gale was going to ride his ass hard for swearing on camera.

“Just cry uncle if it gets too bad.” Using his drilled grip on Granite’s torso, Titan lifted the stone giant up and began slamming him violently into

the wall, over and over as concrete and pieces of Granite rained down at his feet. He kept this up for nearly half a minute then flung his fractured opponent across the room, slamming him into another wall.

“Okay. . . that kind of sucked,” Granite coughed out. Even as his body reshaped itself, he could see Titan’s approaching feet. “Credit where it’s due: those stories about you weren’t all talk. You hit pretty freaking hard.”

Titan grabbed Granite’s leg, gripping so hard that cracks shot through it. “Hitting hard isn’t that big of a deal. Lots of Supers can do it. What makes a good fighter is how well you think through your battles. Also, and I say this as nicely as I can, you haven’t even seen me hit hard yet.”

With that, he swung the massive stone Super over his shoulder like he was doing little more than hoisting a sack of flour. He smashed Granite into the floor. Like he had on the wall earlier, he continued the assault for some time, creating all manner of craters and debris in the previously immaculate floor. Eventually the leg came off in Titan’s hands, so he went back to pummeling Granite’s torso across the walls, only to change it up a few seconds later.

At long last, Gale’s voice rang through the training arena. “Time’s up!”

Titan stopped mid-blow, standing up and giving a small bow to his opponent. Then he handed back the stone arm that he’d been using to attack Granite’s head. Granite accepted the appendage begrudgingly, pulling himself slowly back together now that the onslaught had finally ceased.

“You really don’t go halfway with your attacks, do you?” Granite asked.

Titan flashed him a smile that made Granite feel uneasy in the pit of his reforming stomach. “You might be surprised. Maybe one day you’ll see me in a not-so-friendly environment.”

“Well, I hope you can get as well as you give,” Granite said. “Defense is next, and I know who you’re going against.”

“Let me guess: Gale.”

“Ha! You wish,” Granite said, shaking his large rocky noggin. “No such luck, old man. We’re putting you against our heaviest damage dealer. You have to survive Birdsmen.”





## 44.

Birdsman stepped forward from behind the barrier while as Granite wandered back that direction. The barrier wouldn't hide his substantial bulk, but given that he'd just survived a two-minute lashing from Titan and knew his teammate's power well, he wasn't too worried about catching any crossfire.

Birdsman moved slowly, a man whose age had slowed him the way that no enterprising criminal had been able to. His plodding pace would have been comforting to his opponent, if Titan had been an idiot. He'd read up extensively on Elemental Fury and knew all too well that this man's physique had nothing to do with his power.

"As you inquired with Granite, so I must now ask of you: do you have any vulnerabilities that I should take care to avoid?" Birdsman spoke these words softly when he drew close, his voice weathered yet still tough, like finely tanned leather.

"Not unless you've got a secret ability you're holding in reserve," Titan replied. For a Hero who had been around as long as Birdsman, it was highly unlikely that he'd kept a hidden ace up his sleeve. Unlikely, but not impossible.

"If I did, I'd hardly show it off over a thing like this." The older man gave him a wry smile then walked back across the room. As he did, he started speaking to the cameras, filling his voice with volume and authority.

"We will now commence the defensive portion of the assessment. I shall attack Titan for two minutes or until he calls for me to stop. He is free to dodge or negate my attacks however he pleases, though he may not counterattack me in any way. When time is up, we shall assess how adept he was at defending against the onslaught. Titan, are you ready?"

"One quick question: I've never fought a Super of your kind in one of these before, so is it just you that I can't attack?"

The older Hero gave a small nod. "You are to move and act purely defensively during this portion of the assessment. No exceptions. Any more questions?"

“No, sir. Ready whenever you are.” Titan kept his tone a touch more respectful with Birdman; the man had been a Hero when Owen was still in the Sizemore Tech HCP, and the number of lives he’d saved through the years was commendable.

“The timer starts with my first attack.” Birdman raised his arms, palms facing Titan and fingers outstretched. “Fire Eagle! Lightning Falcon!”

Bursting forth from the thin air a few inches in front of Birdman’s hands came a pair of glowing avian creatures, each so bright it strained the eyes to look at them directly. They soared through the confined space, one made of flames, the other composed of crackling electricity. Each did a single lap around the room then dove directly for Titan.

In the back of his mind, Titan hoped Hexcellent was paying attention to Birdman’s style. The man was an experienced summoner; even a Hero who’d been on the job for years could learn from the way he controlled his creatures. Titan didn’t let this sentiment distract him, however, and he sidestepped Fire Eagle, causing the flaming bird to sear the concrete before returning to the sky. Lightning Falcon hit him square in the shoulder, burying its talons in his flesh; it moved too fast for anyone without super-speed to dodge.

Titan threw himself back toward a wall as Lightning Eagle released its grip. He couldn’t do much, but he hoped he could at least minimize the angles they’d be able to attack from. The large man bounced off the concrete wall, sending a fair bit of debris cascading down it just as Fire Eagle took another shot at him.

This time it didn’t bother diving; instead it unleashed a wide cone of flame from its beak. Titan managed to scramble away, taking another strike from Lightning Eagle in the process. He had to hand it to Birdman: the man was managing to keep him totally off guard. And this was only with two of his summons.

As Titan put some distance between himself and the avian attackers, he heard Birdman say something else. Unfortunately, the crackling bolts of energy that Lightning Eagle hurled from its wings made it impossible for Titan to make out the actual words. He was able to put it together a few seconds later when he was struck from behind with such heat and force that he stumbled forward.

Turning around, Titan already knew the back of his uniform was toast.

Whatever had hit him was far more powerful than lighting or fire. Given that he hadn't been knocked clean across the room, there was only one remaining summon that could have done it.

Floating in the air, burning too hot to look at dead-on, was Plasma Hawk. It flapped its narrow wings once and a lance of energy struck out toward Titan. He jerked to the side, reflexes stepping in where basic processing failed. The beam struck one of the far walls. It lasted only a second, but where it had hit the concrete was gone, revealing a now white-hot metal reinforcement. Even the area around it was bubbling, concrete dripping slowly to the floor.

"Holy sh- crap." Titan said. "I've seen videos, but that thing is *intense* up close."

"You did say you could handle everything in my repertoire," Birdsman pointed out. "Which makes me wonder, why are you jumping around so much?"

"Because unlike some people, I have to pay to replace these damn costumes." Titan leapt up and back as he spoke, dodging a strike from Plasma Hawk, but falling right into Fire Eagle and Lighting Falcon's clutches. The two tore at him until he hit the ground and recovered himself, just in time to narrowly avoid another blast from Plasma Hawk.

By the time the two minutes had finally passed, Titan's outfit was halfway to shambles. His shirt was more rags than covering, and one of the legs of his pants had burned off below the knee. Only his mask, no doubt at Birdsman's direction, had been left unassaulted. The room itself had taken a few knocks as well; the attacks Titan managed to dodge had scorched and melted the concrete. It spoke great lengths about Birdsman's control that the corner where his team was watching remained perfectly unscathed. The only thing in the room completely unharmed, aside from those hidden behind a barrier, was Titan himself. Despite the birds' constant barrage, he'd come through without so much as mild shock or burn.

Gale had watched his refusal to be injured with the same passively detached face she'd worn throughout the entire offensive assessment. They'd known it was a longshot that Birdsman might be able to do even a little visible damage to Titan, but she'd still held on to hope.

In the end, it didn't matter, though. She'd never counted on showing up Titan in either of the first two categories. No, she'd staked their pride on

the final part of the assessment, and as she walked out from behind the barrier, Gale found it hard to keep down her grin.

She was going to break the will of a threat to her city and increase the prestige of her team all in a single blow. This would be a good day.

## 45.

Elemental Fury followed Gale as she moved away from the barrier, fanning out with each step. Birdsman's summons floated back over to him, hovering a few feet above his head. Titan watched all of this with careful eyes, keeping track of as many Supers' positions as possible. By his guess, when things started, he wouldn't have much margin of error to work in.

"Clearly, you did well on the first two assessments," Gale said. "Your strength and endurance are still renowned to this day. However, there is more to being a Hero than brute force. And there is more than one way to be taken down. For the last portion of your exam, I think we would like to see how you fare against a myriad of threats, ones you cannot simply punch your way through."

All five members of Elemental Fury were facing him, spread out in three quarters of a circle. When their assault came, it would be fast and coordinated. These weren't a bunch of kids or amateurs; this was a seasoned team used to working with and relying on one another. Titan's eyes quickly swept his surroundings. He'd done all the prep work he could; now what remained was to see if it would be enough.

"In order to test how you think on your feet, we've decided to do the trial of AMBUSH!"

Gale screamed the last word, and Titan dove toward the floor. He barely avoided the blast of wind as his fingers raced across the ground. Quickly rolling to his feet, he looked up to see where the next attack was coming from. Unfortunately, it was at exactly that moment that his world went black. There was no light, no shapes, not so much as a speck of movement, despite the sounds of motion he could clearly hear around him.

The darkness meant he wasn't able to see the next of Gale's attacks, which struck him in the chest and lifting him off his feet. No sooner was he in air than the humming clatter of footsteps filled his ears. Too fast for a normal person, which meant Spring was racing around him. Titan's mind darted back to the sash she wore that clashed with her outfit. He thrust his right arm up in the air just as Spring turned his legs, left arm, and torso into a tightly coiled cocoon; thankfully, the arm remained free. Then she was gone. In her place came the thundering sound of wind in his ears. He was being lifted off the

ground into the air by what he could only assume was a localized tornado.

Blind, bound, and stuck up in a tornado. He had to hand it to Gale: this was a damn good way to neutralize a strongman. Any single one of these could have slowed one of Titan's kind; all three together was going to bring down almost anyone with that power set.

"According to the rules of this trial, if Titan is immobilized for a consecutive minute, the assessment is over," Gale announced to the cameras and the world at large. She didn't bother saying words like "win" or "lose" since no one technically won an assessment. Besides, there was no need to. If he hung in the air like a trussed pig for all the world to see, there would be a very clear winner here, and it wasn't him.

"Feel free to struggle," Gale said, the wind carrying her whispered words directly to his ears. "It will make for a better show. Fair warning, though: that cloth of Spring's was taken off a tech-genius, and it can hold back a charging elephant. Even if you slip free, you'll still be blind and suspended in the air. You've lost, Titan."

"You know, if I'm being perfectly honest, I really wish I could just let it be at this," Titan said. "I've got nothing against you all, really I don't. Sadly, I can't roll over today. Too many criminals out there, watching, waiting to see if they should still be afraid of me or not. And however small the chance might be, there's also the possibility that my boys will see this. Sorry, Gale. Really I am."

Titan didn't know if the words would reach her; he had no power that let him transmit speech through tornados. All he could do, all he'd ever been able to do, was hit harder than everyone else.

Of course, that didn't mean he hadn't picked up a few other tricks about how to do that well.

First and worst was the cloth. He really hoped Spring had a way to repair it, because otherwise he was going to feel downright guilty about what was necessary. That's what happened when you brought tools into battle, though.

Titan stretched his limbs, slowly spreading the fabric apart. He was as gentle as he could be, but the sound of a metallic ripping still reached his ears once or twice. There was definitely some angry shouting coming from the ground as the cloth fell away from him, that much he could tell.

Next came the wind. If it were an advanced mind he was facing, he'd have been in a much worse position, but tornados were easier to handle. Gale couldn't just grab and hold him up like someone with telekinesis. She had to buffet him with wind, a force which was inherently imprecise. Sure, if he were constrained it was doable, but once he was free it was different ballgame. Titan stuck out his limbs, catching different parts of the winds that sent him spinning about. His rotation increased as his stability fell; he was jerking and dancing about in the tornado, bobbing up and down rapidly. Gale struggled to maintain control, to keep him centered, but after a few seconds the inevitable happened: Titan's hand made contact with the ceiling. As soon as he felt the rough concrete, he punched, sending him hurtling through the air, across the room, and out of Gale's tornado.

Though he hadn't planned on it, this surprise thrust also had the added bonus of moving him faster than Misdirection's illusion could keep him blinded. Titan landed hard and quickly scanned the room. The large black orb that had been wrapped around his head was making a beeline for him. It was as fast as thought, just not fast enough. As soon as Titan saw Misdirection, he reared back his right arm. He'd filled his grip with debris when he first dove to the ground, which he now threw it at her. Its impact would be hard enough to bruise and bleed, but he hoped he'd held back enough not to seriously injure her.

Misdirection let out a yelp of pain as the rocks struck and her focus was shattered. The rest of Elemental Fury faced their opponent, uncertainty creeping into their faces for the first time since he'd stepped in the room. The man who was supposed to already be out of the fight was standing there, unharmed, with his eyes unwaveringly trained on them. Despite the politeness he'd shown them, each felt a kernel of fear form in their gut.

These five weren't the first to find themselves sensing their mortality as they stared down a man who was called unstoppable. It was instinct, the kind that lived in the primitive part of their brain and told them when they'd drawn the attention of something far more dangerous than them. That kind of instinct was old, it was impossible to ignore, and most of all it was correct. They were right to be afraid.

Titan's counterattack had begun.



## 46.

Elemental Fury was caught off guard, but recovered quickly. They'd seen too much action to let one thing going sideways break their focus. Unfortunately for them, Titan was no rookie either, and he knew how to capitalize on small windows of opportunity when they appeared. At this point, it all came down to dealing with the threats in order of their importance, and the top spot on his list was set long before he'd even managed to punch free of the tornado.

Bracing his feet against the cracked wall he'd slammed against, Titan shoved off, firing himself through the room at speeds only Spring could have matched. This assumed, of course, that she was dumb enough to get in front of several hundred pounds of super-strong Hero, which she wasn't. He cleared half the cell in one bound, landing only a few feet from his target. The sound of crackling energy and rumbling steps filled the air as Birdsmen's summons and Granite tried to stop him, but neither was quite fast enough.

"You're down," Titan said as his mighty hand wrapped around the mask-hidden skull of Misdirection, who was still pulling herself off the ground after his rubble assault. In assessments like this, most Heroes were willing to play by the honor system, acknowledging a situation where they would have been knocked out or killed and removing themselves from the fight. It was proper etiquette and saved on accidental injuries, but Titan still kept his grip until he heard Misdirection's agreement.

"Looks like you got me." Misdirection finished pulling herself up and jogged back toward the protection offered by the clear barrier. "But the others won't be so easy."

A streak of avian-shaped electricity descended from the air as soon as Misdirection was clear, grabbing onto Titan's face and attacking with all its might. Damage-wise, the technique was a waste of time, but it did succeed in obscuring Titan's vision and hearing, which he assumed was the real point. They'd clearly formed a backup plan to keep him off-balance in case Misdirection was taken down; Titan's respect for this team was growing by the minute.

Granite slammed into his back, sending Titan sailing across the room. The electric bird maintained its grip, pecking and slashing at Titan's face.

Through the crackle of lightning, he heard the wind whipping as Gale prepared for another attack. Getting out of her tornados was doable, he'd already proved that, but getting bound up in one would give the rest of the team time to regroup. That was something he couldn't afford, not at this juncture, so Titan steeled his resolve. It was time to do some damage.

He grabbed the summoned creature in front of him, ignoring the shrill screech that tore from its beak. Like he'd explained to Hexcellent only weeks before, for something to be able to touch you, you had to be able to touch it. Bouncing around the room like a pinball during the defensive phase hadn't been fun, but it had given him the chance to verify that these creatures were making contact with him; they weren't just bird-shaped energy. They had a physical presence, and while he was barred from countering during that part of the exam, no such restriction existed anymore.

It took a lot more effort than he was expecting, but Titan managed to keep a grip on Lightning Falcon and tear it in half. There was a boom and a burning crackle that washed over him as he landed, so loud it nearly drowned out the painful yelp that Birdsmen let break through his lips. Summoners had it better than a lot of Supers in that they didn't have to get their own hands dirty; however, their power still had a risk. Destroying one of their summons caused mental feedback that hurt like hell; it could even knock the weaker Supers out entirely. Birdsmen wasn't quite that frail; he shook off the pain and focused on the other two circling birds, planning his next attack.

Bad as he was, Birdsmen wasn't the next target in Titan's list of priorities. That honor fell to Spring, the super-speed Hero who'd tried to wrap him up like an early Christmas present to her team. Her attacks wouldn't do anything to Titan, but she wasn't functioning as offense in this battle. No, she'd clearly been given the same task as Misdirection: field control. Just because wrapping him had failed didn't mean she didn't have other tricks up her sleeve. In fact, after reading up on her reputation, Titan would have been genuinely offended if that was all she brought to the party.

Granite had reoriented from his charge and was barreling toward Titan, just as Gale unleashed a blast of wind that would no doubt take him off his feet and send him hard into a wall. The attacks were good, clean and focused in a way that theoretically left him nowhere to go but back, which was a delay at best. In fact, it was how polished the maneuver was that tipped Titan to what they were trying. At this point in the battle, things should have been more chaotic. Any tactic that clean was rehearsed, which meant the real goal wasn't to hit him with either; it was to pressure him in to making the

move they wanted. Titan had no idea what was waiting for him if he stepped back; he just knew it wouldn't be fun.

At the last moment, Titan made his choice, breaking left, away from Gale's attack and right into the massive stone monster known as Granite's crushing path. The Hero's rocky eyes widened as he realized Titan had caught on to their plan, but no amount of realization was going to stop the momentum of a charging creature whose weight measured in the tons. He tried to defend, but it was already too late. Titan slammed his fingers into Granite's chest and flipped the stone monster over his shoulder, right onto the spot where he would have stepped if he dodged their attacks per the plan.

No sooner had Granite hit the ground than he was knocked a few feet upward by an explosion that coated his back and the floor in green goop. He tried to free himself, but whatever the substance was, it seemed to be difficult to break away from.

"If it had been you, that would have been enough force to stick you to the ceiling," Spring said, suddenly behind him. "Pretty smart, realizing it was a trap. Course, you did leave yourself open during that throw."

Titan barely had time to register the explosion that came from a small device stuck to his back before it sent him stumbling headfirst into a far wall. In the brief time he spent with his head smashed against the concrete, he felt hands moving impossibly fast, placing more charges against his body.

"This is for tearing my capture sash. Mending that thing is a bitch."

This time Titan barely even heard the explosion; his ears were filled up too quickly with the green goop as it cascaded over him. One of these bombs had been enough to lift Granite's massive body off the ground and stick him to the floor. The five that Spring had stuck on Titan drove him half a foot deep into the wall and coated his back from head to toe in the stuff.

Even for someone like him, it was a less than ideal situation.

## 47.

Titan couldn't hear what they were saying on the other side of his gooey tomb, but it was no doubt Gale re-explaining the one minute rule to those watching, maybe adding an addendum about the limitation being for his own good, lest he suffocate. He tested the goop carefully and found it stronger than he was expecting. It was well-designed, a material that was both flexible and tough. Spring used the charges freely, as if she weren't concerned about the supply. These were probably either made in house by some retired team member or purchased from a freelance tech-genius. One of the countless benefits of having a legacy team and a budget.

Of course, even if it were the most powerful binding goop in the world it still had a fault: it might be indestructible, but the material it bonded with almost certainly wasn't. If they'd caught him in midair with this stuff, it very well could have been a different story, but they'd trapped Titan against a solid wall, and that gave him leverage.

He began pulling himself backward, keenly aware of the resistance that the goop was imposing. It was strong stuff, no doubt about it. Pity the same couldn't be said for the concrete it was fastened to. When he'd gotten far enough away to move his arms, Titan pressed his hands carefully against the surface in front of him and gave an open-palmed shove.

A tremendous cracking sound filled the air as Titan tore himself and a considerable chunk of concrete free from the wall. Spring was nearby, glaring at him with a mix of shock and annoyance, Birdsman seemed focused on keeping his summons ready to act, and Gale was flat-out glowering. That last expression told him he'd made it before time was up, though he doubted it was by a lot.

Titan didn't waste a second now that he was free. What he had at the moment was just a hunch, but it was better than nothing in a situation like this. He charged through the room, goop on his back and concrete stuck all over him, on a path straight for Birdsman.

"Cocky." Birdsman made a quick motion. Plasma Hawk soared through the air, putting itself between Titan and his target and lashing out with a beam of energy. Titan barely had seconds to act: only the fact that he'd been counting on the interruption let him move in time. He quickly twirled around

on his heel, a move more graceful than many would have suspect the large man of pulling off, and turned his goop covered back to Plasma Hawk. He drew his left arm in to his chest just as its beam hit.

The bad news was that the rest of Titan's shirt was effectively decimated in the hit, the force of which caused him to stumble forward, but the upside was well worth the tradeoff. That burning hot plasma had seared right through the green material coating his back, scorching it off into liquid and an almost-certainly toxic green mist.

"You're smarter than I was expecting," Spring said. "Most of your type just know how to smash and get punched."

"I've picked up few critical thinking skills during my years as a Hero," Titan shot back. "Using an enemy's assets against them is a good one, but my personal favorite has always been field advantage." At that, Titan lifted his leg and slammed it down, striking on of the many half-melted sections of flooring left from his earlier battle with Birdsmen. The weakened concrete fractured, splintering off several feet in three directions. His next attack sent more tremors out, widening the already broken gaps and creating four new ones.

"Cute, trying to make it hard for me to run. Don't think we'll just let you do what you want, though."

Spring had barely gotten the words out before the column of wind struck Titan from the side, hurling him against the far wall. This time, he twisted in midair, making sure his back slammed into the concrete. This meant he was face-to-face with Spring as she tried to catch him from behind once more. Unlike Granite, she was more than capable of redirecting her speed and swerved off to the side rather than be caught in a clumsy grab from the giant man.

Normally, being backed into a wall was a bad thing, but at the moment it was actually one of the better places Titan could find himself. Gale wouldn't be able to batter him about so easily with a solid surface right behind him, and Spring was smart enough to avoid getting close enough to be caught. That only left Birdsmen to attack, which would be an annoyance at best. Sadly, this situation also meant Titan had almost no opportunity to bring them down either, since moving away would destroy his defensive advantage. Were he the type of person to worry about defense, that might have actually worried him.

Bracing his feet against the wall, Titan shot himself forward, replicating his attack from only moments earlier as he barreled toward Birdsmen. The old summoner wasn't the most important threat to stop at the moment, but he'd have to go down eventually. Taking him out would leave Elemental Fury with only two pieces on the board—three if Granite pulled himself free—and Titan was confident he could bring them both down given enough time. It would be easier without those damn bird distractions, though.

Plasma Hawk darted into Titan's path again, but this time the charging Hero didn't bother to turn, dodge, or avoid the creature in any way. He kept right on going, taking the beam of energy that shot from its beak head on, his chest smashing into the avian energy creature only seconds later. As it swiped at him, Titan grabbed Plasma Hawk in his right hand and squeezed as hard as he could. This one was smaller than Lightning Falcon, and he just barely managed to get its body engulfed between his fingers. As it turned out, barely was still enough.

A wave of heat washed over Titan as the summon was crushed into non-existence. Birdsmen let out a grunt as he staggered back. A small bit of blood trickled down from the older man's nose, falling to the broken floor as he tried to keep from swaying on his feet. With enough time, he might have been able to get Fire Eagle in place as defense, but Titan showed zero sign of slowing down. There was no time for anyone to act. Anyone save for a person with super-speed, of course.

Spring appeared on his left, keeping pace as she reared back with what appeared to be another bomb. She thrust forward, her coordination incredible given the speed she was moving at. Just like few people could throw a well-aimed punch while sprinting, super-speeders also had to slow down to attack a foe. Their slow was still fast, it was just in the range of humans. That was most super-speeders, anyway. As Spring's hand drew closer, Titan realized he wouldn't be able to grab her, no matter how quickly he moved. It was all he could do to flip his arm around, but flip it he did, and as Spring's hand smashed against him, Titan's face lit up in a victorious grin.

"What the hell!" Spring pulled against the green goop that was binding her hand, and the bomb still clutched in it, to his arm. "This got burned off!"

"I kept a little safe. Thought it might come in handy." Titan jerked to a stop, feet sliding against and cracking the already-shattered concrete, then grabbed Spring's head in his hands as he'd done with Misdirection. "By the

by, you're out."

"You dick," Spring muttered. She reached down and undid the fastening on the yellow glove that clothed her hand, leaving it and the bomb still on Titan's forearm but releasing her arm from its imprisonment. Then she was gone, zipping over behind the safety barrier and leaving no impediment between Titan and Birdsman.

"Do I need to do the theatrics?" Titan asked

"No, you've clearly got me. I can still concede when I'm bested," Birdsman admitted. "Good show, Titan. Nice to see you haven't lost your touch. Next time we should play on a bigger stage, though. I think my fourth bird might just have changed the outcome of this assessment."

"Well, it isn't over yet," Titan said. He looked into the air, where Gale was hovering as she waited for Birdsman to get clear. She was one of the biggest threats on the field, but he'd purposely saved her for last. In a small cell like this, with teammates around, she wouldn't really be able to cut loose. Now that it was just the two of them left, he hoped Gale would finally come at him full force.

No matter how it went, he was settling this matter for good.

## 48.

The small pieces of debris near Titan's foot began to move first, followed by the larger chunks as the wind picked up. Across the room, he saw the remaining members of Elemental Fury pulling the clear barrier to the wall and anchoring it firmly. Whatever Gale was conjuring up, her team knew enough to take precautions, which meant it was likely to be a doozy.

"You're powerful. More powerful than I expected, I'll give you that." Gale wasn't bothering to use her wind-whispering or whatever she'd done when he was in the tornado. She belted these words through the air, for all those watching at home to hear. "But you're reckless; you take too many chances that could get people hurt."

"No disrespect meant, but sometimes we have to take risks to get the job accomplished. It's not something I do lightly; it's just something that occasionally has to be done." Titan noticed that the roar of the wind was still increasing; he'd had to raise his voice midway through the reply to be heard. His already-burned and torn pants flapped against him furiously.

"I disagree; well-laid plans and execution can minimize risk and overcome any obstacle."

"Looks like we're going to have to agree to disagree." Titan readied himself as he saw her eyes shift about the room. She was buying time with the conversation, which had been fine for the first few moments, but Titan had no intention in getting swept up in whatever she was planning. If he went into the air on her terms with no bystanders to worry about, there was no telling when he'd finally hit the ground again.

As quickly as he could, Titan raised his right foot high off the ground, pointed the toe of his reinforced boot downward, and thrust it into the concrete below. Unlike with his shattering stomps against Spring, Titan wasn't trying to spread the force out to ripple through the stone. He wanted it all concentrated in a single point.

A mighty crack of splintering concrete filled the air, audible even over Gale's storm. Titan's foot sank through the floor past his ankle, effectively anchoring him. Fast as he'd moved, he was still barely in time. The blast of wind that struck his chest was tremendous, so powerful he nearly slipped out of his boot as he was lifted up. Thankfully, his foot covering held and he



remained rooted in place.

Gale struck again and again, furious blasts coming at Titan from nearly every direction. He managed to lower himself down to the ground, digging his fingers into the floor to help solidify his hold. Even with appendages literally jammed into the concrete, it was all he could do to stay in place. If they'd built their training room from weaker material he'd have been airborne already. The assault was incredible, which meant it also had to be taxing. Using abilities didn't come free; they wore a person down like any activity. Even someone like Gale would only be able to keep it for so long.

Of course, the ground would also only hold for so long, so neither of them was in a perfect situation.

Finally, Titan noticed a steadily-increasing lull between attacks. He chanced a look and saw Gale, eyes still blazing, but with a noticeable sheen of sweat on her forehead. As a trained Hero, she surely had plenty more left in the tank; however, the all-out assault had definitely left her drained. She was probably trying to think of another way to come at him, to negate his strategy of rooting himself. At that moment, she was more focused on what she should do than on what was actually happening, and that was what Titan had been waiting for throughout the entire match.

His left leg, the only appendage he had not thrust into the concrete, shifted back as he braced his foot against the corner where the wall and floor met. The first two times he'd used his trick of blasting off the walls he'd been sure to keep the range very limited. Gale was smart, she had a keen eye, and given her powers, she was probably great at visually gauging distances. She'd floated high into the air and far enough away that she'd be out of range if he replicated the technique. Which was precisely the reason Titan hadn't let her see how strong his jumps could really be.

Titan released his hold on the concrete and soared through the air. His right boot fell apart in tatters; it had been dug in too deeply to get extracted when he propelled himself up. Only his near-indestructibility had saved his foot from a similar fate. As he flew toward Gale, he saw the shock in her face as she realized he was easily going to reach her. With her abilities, she might have still been able to redirect him or dodge; that was why he'd waited until her mind slipped away from the battlefield. It probably made a difference of less than a second in her reaction time.

One second that secured her loss.

His arms grabbed her before his body could make impact, bending slowly to cushion his momentum. As soon as Titan had a grip on her, he spun around in the air so that his back smashed into the wall, sparing her from a very painful, and likely bloody, sandwiching. The two tumbled to the ground, where Titan landed on his back, Gale still clutched in his large hands, saved from yet another impact.

“Unless you’ve got some kind of ultra-resistance that would stop me from squishing you, I think we can both agree that you’re down,” Titan said.

“That was a beyond idiotic maneuver,” Gale snapped. Her voice was firm, but Titan could feel the slight shivers racing through her body. It was no doubt a mix of nerves and adrenaline dumping through the body, a sensation that he was all too familiar with. “If I’d managed to stop you, you’d have been completely in my domain.”

“It was a risk,” Titan admitted. “But it paid off.”

“That is not the *point*! It doesn’t matter that it happened to work; it was a stupid, dangerous maneuver. You would have lost if it didn’t.”

“No, I’d have just been in a shitty position. I’d have figured something else out. I’ve got a lot of practice. Now are you going to admit that I got you so we can be done with this ridiculousness?”

Gale’s face reddened beneath her mask, but she gave a small nod. “I concede that you could have taken me out of the fight. You successfully subdued every member of Elemental Fury in the ambush and provided a strong showing in your assessment. Should we every require someone of your. . . talents. . . we will contact you.”

Titan smiled and set Gale carefully on the ground. He pulled himself up next, giving a polite nod to the others that were emerging from the barrier. “You guys put up a hell of a fight.”

“That means so much coming from you.” Gale barely managed to slip enough false-sincerity into her tone to cover the venom in her voice.

“I get it; you still don’t like me, or you think I’m dangerous, or whatever.” Titan lowered his voice to a point that he hoped wouldn’t be picked up by the audience at home.

“I worry that you’re reckless, and that you take unnecessary risks. Our town already has enough Heroes doing that; the last thing they need is an idol

to hold up as an example of how that type of thinking works.” Gale’s own tones had lowered as well. This no doubt looked suspicious to the viewers but was still better than them being overheard.

“You know, I’m getting real sick and tired of you making all these assumptions about me. First it was that I’m a media whore, then it was that I was reckless; I don’t even want to know what you’ll come up with tomorrow. Let’s be real clear: *you’re* the one who pushed this event into being, so think hard before you accuse anyone of being spotlight hungry. As for the reckless thing. . .” Titan grabbed her shoulder and pointed across the room, where Spring was freeing Granite with some sort of spray-can solvent.

“I brought down every member of your team, and not one of them has more than light bruising. My entire power is built around hitting so hard I take people out of the fight, and none of you need so much as aspirin, let alone a healer. Think long and hard about that fact next time you want to call me reckless.”

Titan released his grip and walked across the room to help with Granite, leaving a silent Gale staring at him from behind.

## 49.

Owen had just finished changing into his backup pants when he heard the door to the locker room open. He sat down on a bench and began to lace a pair of fresh boots, moving with a deliberate precision. Owen had snapped many a pair of laces before getting his strength under control.

“How’d I do?”

“Not bad, not bad at all.” Lenny took a seat next to him, his short legs almost dangling in the air from the height of the bench. “Your offense and defense portions reminded everyone that in a contest of pure might, always bet on Titan. Obviously we expected that part, though. What really impressed me was the show you put on with that last section. You let those folks shine pretty bright.”

“I didn’t want to walk in and decimate them; they’ve got criminals to stop too. Hell, given my other duties, they’ve got a lot more than I do.” Owen finished his first boot and moved on to the second. He’d hoped that he wouldn’t need a backup costume from this assessment, but practicality and experience had both demanded he bring one along.

“You struck a nice balance. To the untrained eye, it looked like things could have gone the other way if a few things had broken differently. They showed off their skills against a legend, and you reminded them why you have that term associated with you in the first place. Overall, it was a win across the board.” Lenny leaned forward and stared at his client. “So why do you look like someone just stole your ice cream and kicked your puppy?”

“I don’t know,” Owen replied. “Honestly, I realize this is about as good an outcome as I could have hoped for; I guess I’m just a little miffed that I had to be here in the first place.” With the second boot done, he planted both feet on the floor and turned to meet his agent’s eyes. “When I came back, I said I was doing it to make a difference. To help people and stay out of the petty politics and bullshit that took me out the first time. Here we are, not even a month later, and I’m in a stupid pissing contest for no reason other than a Hero thought I might cause some trouble. I let myself get roped back in; now I’m pissed at myself for allowing it to happen and for the system for bringing me to this point.”

“It’s a wet mess of shit, but that’s the life,” Lenny replied. “The

reputations, the media stuff, it's all important. Come on, Titan. You've been at this for a long time; you're not some HCP senior who just got the speech. You know what Heroes are really here for. Coming back in meant you were taking that burden on along with all the others."

"I'm fully aware of what I committed to. Just in one of those moods, I guess."

"Ah yes, 'those moods,' what fuckers they are." Lenny pulled himself up from the bench and reached into his pocket. He pulled out his cell phone and began tapping on the screen. "Might have something that will pull you out of that funk, though. Here."

Owen took the phone from Lenny; its screen was already playing a video file. It took him a moment to realize what he was seeing, until he noticed the familiar costumes of his PEERS team right before a loud cheer burst forth from them. He could just make out the shape of the giant television in the corner, which all of them were watching with rapt attention. They let another scream, and Hexcellent clapped like someone had just complimented her tattoos.

"They were cheering for you so damned loudly I was half-tempted to kick them out of my VIP accommodations," Lenny explained. "But in the end I thought doing this might be more helpful."

Owen wasn't sure what part of the fight they were watching; he only knew that they all suddenly grew very quiet. Moments later they all jumped up from their seats in excitement, even Zone and Bubble Bubble, though the latter did manage to seem more composed than the others.

"That was when Spring stuck all those weird goo bombs on you. Poor kids really thought you might be down for the count." Lenny reached over and took his phone back as the file finished playing, then patted Owen on his enormous shoulder. "It's easy to lose sight of what matters when you're entrenched in all the bullshit, but there are people out there who are happier for seeing you succeed. You are making a difference by being back in the life; I bet some kid out there has already hung a new Titan poster over his bed. So, you still having a mood?"

"I think I'm good." Owen pulled himself off the bench, pausing only to make sure that his costume was on straight. There were going to be reporters and cameras when he stepped out of this locker room; he wanted to make sure that Titan looked his best. Just in case fans were watching. "Hey,

Lenny, did I ever thank you?”

“For the generous portion of the profits I got us from this whole clusterfuck? No, you didn’t, but nothing says thanks quite like a bottle of fifty-year-old scotch.”

“Not for the money, though I’ll be watching for a check. I meant for making me join up with a team when I came back. As hard as I tried to fight it at the time, it seems so obvious now that you were right. Those kids have probably kept me more centered than anything else since I’ve gotten back in, and I wouldn’t have them if not for you.”

“Any agent worth his salt knows what his client needs to stay in peak condition. For you, it’s a network of people who depend on you. For others, it’s ego-stroking sycophants or more drugs and sex than a seventies rock festival. Yours involves a lot less blowback, which means a lot less work for me, so it’s my pleasure. Now let’s get out there already, and remember to pimp the fact that we’ll have DVDs for sale next week.”

“Whatever you say, Lenny.”

## 50.

When Owen finally got home that night, he was worn out. Not physically, of course; even as respectable a fight as Elemental Fury had put up wasn't enough to drain his body's reserves. No, this was a mental weariness that came from shaking hands, smiling for cameras, and just generally schmoozing. He'd have skipped all the post-assessment junk if it was at all viable, but even ignoring the fact that there might be people looking up to him, it was necessary damage control.

Seeing their Heroes fight against one another could be rough on those who looked to them as a united front, especially children. The interviews and smiles between Titan and people who'd just been trying to bring him down showed everyone that it was all good-natured, nothing more than a game people with super powers played against one another. The truth of what motivated the match in the first place was irrelevant; all that mattered was making sure everyone outside the combatants thought it had been their version of a hard-fought baseball game.

Once he was finally safe inside his sparse bedroom, Owen peeled away the layers of Titan, thankful to be simply himself again, if only for a short while. Lenny was already talking about a few new meetings and perhaps a sponsorship deal, opportunities that had come in so fast there was no way the small agent hadn't already been working on them long before the bout. Lenny was the best, but that also meant being his client could get a bit tiring from time to time.

A long, hot shower washed away enough of Owen's fugue that when he stepped into his room, he quickly noticed a small light blinking on his bedside table. It was his Hero earpiece, letting him know that he had messages. They were non-vital; otherwise Dispatch would have found a way to contact him. No, the light only came on when one Hero wanted to relay something to another who was considered offline. They'd probably been sent when Owen was doing all his interviews; he'd made sure to let Dispatch know he didn't want any non-emergency interruptions.

With a weary sigh, Owen picked up the communicator and slid it into his ear. "Titan, checking in for message relay."

"Dispatch recognizes Titan, and congratulates him on his showing

today.”

Neutral and flat though her words were, Owen felt a smile tugging at the corners of his lips. He remembered her encouragement from earlier in the day with a fond glow. Dispatch tried to keep herself permanently neutral, but every now and then a touch of her true self shined through.

“Thank you for the congratulations, and the encouragement,” Owen replied.

“No thanks required. Are you ready for your messages?”

“I am.” There was a slight click on the other side of the line as a recording started up. A few seconds of silence rolled and a familiar voice began speaking in Owen’s ear.

“Titan, this is Topsy. Wanted to say I caught the show today, and you did us old-timers proud. Way to remind them what the Gentle Hammers were all about. Anyway, we’ve known each other too long for me to beat around the bush: I’m sure you know what happened with my team a while back. I could use your help, if you don’t mind coming on to do a little freelance consulting. Every remaining member of the Wild Bucks saw what you did today, and I think they’d listen to whatever advice you offered. I understand if your plate is too full, just let me know.”

Silence returned as Topsy’s message ended. Owen would no doubt accept his friend’s request; that much was a mere trifle of what was owed between them. However, he had no intention of saying anything inspiring to these young Heroes. Instead, he was going to lay down the kind of law that was etched into stone by prophets.

“Titan, this is Zero.” A new voice was speaking on the communicator, and Owen realized that the next message had begun to play. “We’ve met once or twice, though I’ve never had the pleasure of working with you. You may or may not be aware, but I am no longer working active Hero duty; I have retired to be the dean of one of the Hero Certification Programs. There is a small matter I’d like to discuss with you, should you have the time. Feel free to call through Dispatch; she can plug you in to my usual line of communication. Thank you.”

Well, that couldn’t be good. Owen knew very well who Zero was: the Hero who had retired to run the Lander Hero Certification Program. The same HCP that had accepted five former-Powered into its ranks, one of them with the same last name as Owen himself. He was all too familiar with the Lander



HCP, and whatever reason Zero had for calling him, it almost certainly had to be a bad one.

“Salutations and congratulations, my good oaf.” It took Owen a minute to place this voice; it was familiar, but not excessively so. He realized who it was only a second before they gave their name anyway. “This is Jeremiah, in case you’ve already forgotten my voice after our long discussion on theoretical robotics. I’m calling because while you were knocking the stuffing out of the biggest team on the block, I may have found a bit more interesting information. There’s no need to try and return my call; in fact, you won’t be able to if you try, not for a few days. Instead, you can meet me tomorrow night at The Sleek Minx around seven. Have your costume ready, but come in wearing civvies. Or don’t, if you aren’t all that curious. Up to you, though I will say this much: I do not expect tomorrow night to be boring.”

“That concludes your messages,” Dispatch said. “Would you like me to patch you through to anyone?”

Owen considered his options. The one he most wanted to talk with was Jeremiah, but Subtlety Heroes rarely joked about being unreachable. It was the smart move, too, luring Owen in with the subject that interested him in order to have extra muscle on hand. Jeremiah was clearly good at what he did, which made the prospect of seeing what lead he’d caught all the more tempting. Still, he’d said he’d be unreachable, so there was no point in trying to call.

Topsy was the more obvious choice, but Owen wanted to mull things over a bit before he called his old friend. They needed to be clear on what Owen would be doing if he went over to talk to the Wild Bucks, and there was no way for Owen to do that until he’d actually figured out what he *wanted* to do with them. Details would change as he learned the situation, but he still needed to go in with limits and an outline.

That left Zero, the one Owen was dreading the most. If the Lander HCP Dean was calling him, then it had to be something bad. Save for one week together last spring, Owen hadn’t seen his sons since he left his family, and even that reunion hadn’t exactly been heartwarming. No, the only reason the dean would call him instead of their mother was if it was something to do with their powers. Owen was the closest match to Hershel and Roy’s abilities that he knew of, so if an issue came up then he was likely the best resource for fixing it.

At least, that was what he hoped. There was also the possibility, no matter how small, that something really bad had happened. The sort of bad that required parental notification. The boys had been doing better and the HCP ran a tight ship. . . but accidents did happen. Owen's voice was heavy as he gave Dispatch her orders.

“Please connect me with Zero.”

## 51.

Owen exited the town car as it idled at the curb. When his sizable form departed, the frame lifted up several inches, free of the burden weighing it down. A valet rushed over, but the driver waved him off. Say what Owen might about Mordent Holdings, that town car policy wasn't always a bad thing. It meant that after a long day, Owen didn't have to drive or jog to meet up with Jeremiah. Plus, he was able to stash some of his costume's bulkier components in the town car's back seat.

It was the first true break he'd caught all day. Dealing with last night's messages had necessitated several calls to Lenny, who was less than thrilled by Owen's request, as well calls to Zero and Topsy. While it was nice to speak with his old friend, Owen couldn't help noticing the weariness in Topsy's voice as they'd gone over their calendars to find a mutually open date. It hurt to hear his former partner so drained, and it was made all the worse by the fact that Owen knew he very well might be adding to Topsy's stress.

Dealing with Zero, at least, was a straightforward affair. Things with the boys were fine, thankfully; what Zero needed was a favor. The man was professional through and through: he said what he wanted then immediately entered negotiation mode to get it. That in itself wasn't impressive, but it spoke to Zero's understanding that this was the strategy Owen would respond best to. Knowing how to come at people was nearly as important as what was said when the dealing began. Thankfully, Owen wouldn't have to deal with Zero for a little while, so it meant he didn't have any conflicts for dinner.

The Sleek Minx was an upscale restaurant, though not so refined that they actually imposed a dress code. It was the sort of place where one who underdressed was browbeaten and silently shamed rather than flat-out refused service. Owen drew a few looks as he walked through the front door; he'd donned a button-down and a nice pair of slacks but refused to trade in his boots for something more appropriate. If there was a chance this night might end in a fight, Owen wasn't going to be caught trying to maneuver in some slick-soled wingtips.

No sooner had the host looked up from his podium than a knowing look spread across his gaunt face. "You must be Mr. Micah's guest. Please, follow me." The host turned and began heading down a hallway, barely even waiting for Owen to realize he was being led.

As the two walked, Owen took in the ambiance of the restaurant. It was an older building, lots of molding along the walls and ceiling, with every wall painted the same shade of ivory. The large tables had white sprawling cloths and ample space between them; this was not the sort of establishment that crammed in as many diners as possible. Each table was a small island, and no doubt the cost of eating at it reflected that. Here, they clearly courted guests of high quality rather than quantity.

Jeremiah rose as Owen approached, reaching over and shaking his hand. “Nice to see you again.” Before the handshake was even done, the host had melted away, resuming his place at the podium down the hall.

“You, too.” Owen took a seat, which Jeremiah mirrored. He felt pleased to notice that his chair was a touch larger than the others in the restaurant. It was nice, being able to sit comfortably for a change. “Also, Mr. Micah? Got a thing for prophets I take it?”

“I simply like to commit to my themes,” Jeremiah replied. “I feel many of our kind are too lax in that practice. You have to find the fun where you can. Wine?” He gestured to the open bottle which was chilling in a bucket next to the table. From the level remaining, Jeremiah had already gone through a fair bit by himself.

“No, thanks,” Owen replied.

“Ah right, where is my head? You’re a beer man. We’ll have to get you a menu when the waitress comes by. They have some excellent craft choices.”

“I’m not really here for the beer,” Owen said.

“Yes, I’m perfectly aware of why you’re here, but if you’ll recall I had you show up incognito, which means we are ostensibly two friends sitting down for dinner.” Jeremiah’s tone never lost its cheerful tone; his smile never wavered. All the same, Owen took the hint.

“Right. Maybe I’ll try a glass of wine after all.”

Jeremiah smiled, plucking a glass from the table and pouring Owen a generous helping. Once he tasted it, Owen was surprised to find it wasn’t all that bad. Not a beer, but not terrible.

“Now then, would you like to know why we’re here?” Jeremiah asked.

“Is it safe to talk?”

“That’s my job to worry about, and I assure you we’re fine. I called you here for two reasons: the first being that there was an interesting break-in at a cutting edge lab two days ago. That in itself isn’t so strange—thievery and corporate espionage do occur—but what’s fascinating is that the robber didn’t loot the place. Only a few easily-replaced prototypes for a new type of high-powered portable battery were stolen, along with a generous amount of data. This speaks to someone stealing knowledge, not equipment.”

“You just said corporate espionage,” Owen pointed out. “Maybe someone is trying to get a leg up on their competitor?”

Jeremiah shook his head. “This was a facility under government contract, one of those that technically don’t exist. Any technology replicated or gleaned from their research will have whatever company releases it brought up on charges ranging all the way to treason. Adding in that the technology didn’t have many weapons-level applications, at least none that trump what’s already out there, and it seems to me like someone was looking to build a better robot. This is largely conjecture, of course, but you did request to be kept in the loop as much as possible. My loop often includes speculation and dead ends; such is the burden of those in my field.”

“No, I appreciate it,” Owen said. “You never know what clue is going to be the one that cracks things open. I assume that’s why we’re here tonight? A lead on someone that might be able to confirm some link?”

“Hmm? Oh, no, nothing like that. We’re here because of the second reason I wanted to meet you for dinner,” Jeremiah replied.

“Which is?”

“Which is simply that you likely wouldn’t have come if I’d just asked you out on a date.”

Owen pushed his chair back from the table carefully, making sure not to destroy either one of them and inadvertently cause a scene. “Cute trick, but I have real work I could be doing.”

“I know perfectly well that you do, just like I know that you’ve got the scent of those robots and aren’t likely to let it go. You hardly became renowned for being the kind of man who backed down or gave up. Seeing as I’m the one who is most likely to actually run them down, and I do have a few more tidbits to share, perhaps you should at least be polite and hear me out.” If Jeremiah was at all bothered by Owen’s reaction, it didn’t show.

“You tricked me. There’s not much more I need to know.”

“Come now: of course I tricked you. For one thing, that’s my job; it would be like me getting mad at you for lifting weights. Anyway, we both know you wouldn’t have come if I’d been upfront, and for all the wrong reasons. Let me make a new proposal: hear me out on why I used subterfuge. If, at the end, you see no truth in my reasoning, then we’ll part ways and I’ll keep you in the loop on your prey. If, however, you can acknowledge that I might have been just a bit right, you stay and finish dinner.”

Owen wavered for a few seconds then slid back up to the table. Much as he disliked being kept in the dark, Jeremiah wasn’t entirely wrong about that being what Subtlety Heroes did. Sometimes they needed to move others into position without being able to share information on why. After a few years, most of them thought nothing of light trickery and manipulation. One had to look at their intentions to get a measure of them, and the only way he’d know Jeremiah’s was to listen.

“Talk.”

“Very well.” Jeremiah plucked the wine bottle out of the ice bucket and topped himself off. “I tricked you into coming here, in this context, because we both know you’d have turned me down if I was upfront. Now, my ego is quite healthy and I don’t mind rejection, but only if I’m actually the thing being rejected. Ever since you came back you’ve clearly been shutting away your personal life, trying to make all of who you are about the job. The reasons are obvious: you don’t want to give the media any fuel and you’re probably a bit gun-shy after what happened with your last public tryst. I’d bet

you even emotionally abstained during those years running the bar, keeping your heart locked away.”

Owen’s eyes, trained on Jeremiah’s face, narrowed. He’d never given Jeremiah his real name. Even if he had, the bar, Tartarus, was run under so many fake identities and shell companies that it should have been impossible to trace back to him. Being a Subtlety Hero was one thing, but this was a step beyond.

Jeremiah raised his brows and smiled in response. “What? Did you really expect me not to be a bit curious? Even before I actually met you, the rumors of your return were more than enough to provoke a touch of research. I couldn’t make sense of it all, however, until that day in the bar. That was when I figured out what would motivate such curious, seemingly single-minded behavior. That was when I saw all the guilt that’s weighing you down.”

“I’m not. . . I feel bad for leaving others in the lurch,” Owen replied. “People probably got hurt because I wasn’t there. I should feel guilty. That’s what you feel when you fuck things up.”

“And I have no doubt your penance will be a long one,” Jeremiah said. “But you’re allowed to be more than just the servant of the masses, you know. It shouldn’t be the only aspect of your life. You get to be a person, to have a life. If all you are is the job, then you lose touch with the things worth fighting for. This is a talk we usually give rookies; I shouldn’t have to remind someone like you.”

“I know the talk, and I know the points.” Owen reached over and actually took another drink of the wine. It was better than nothing. “I’m just not there.”

“Let me guess: you’re afraid if you do find romance and the media gets wind, it will kick up the same shitshow as before? No, that can’t be all of it. You’re the type that always takes on a challenge from others. Hmmm.” Jeremiah drummed his fingers on the table, gaze never wavering from Owen. “You’re scared that it will break you again. You don’t even have a reason why you think it would, but the idea that you might run a second time, that you might be the one who destroys you, is probably one of the only things you still feel genuine fear over. That’s why you’re just the job. If nothing else exists, nothing can make you run.”

“Do people really go in for all your psycho-analytical bullcrap?”

“Some do, most don’t,” Jeremiah admitted. “Few people find the truth palatable. Perhaps that was why I found you worth pursuing: you do not strike me as one to shirk easily.”

“Yeah, about that pursuing. I’m flattered, but I doubt this will work out,” Owen said.

“So sure already? We have barely scratched the surface of getting to know one another. It certainly can’t be a physical rejection; I still keep a fit shape and my handsomeness is objectively undeniable. Or perhaps you simply prefer men more rough and tumble like yourself, rather than the stuffy intellectual types.” Jeremiah grinned.

Owen had to admit the young man was handsome, if a bit cockier than was warranted. Still, it didn’t change the fact that there were serious obstacles in their way.

“You forgot to add in that you’re at least ten years younger than me, and that we both work in jobs that are incredibly demanding, not to mention dangerous as hell.”

“I see. You’re afraid to get close to me because you’re afraid you’ll then lose me.” Jeremiah finished off his wine and set down the glass. “Very well, I think that’s enough offense for this meeting. Since I assume you’ll have to yield my words held some truth, and as such you are now obligated to stay for dinner as a man of his word, let us make another new deal. I promise to keep the dinner on friendly terms, sticking to platonic subjects and business at hand, if you’ll make me a promise in return.”

“What’s the promise?” Owen asked.

“Promise me that, should you actually find that I’m not your type, you won’t make the next man whose eye you catch jump through so many hoops to win your affection. Self-denial is all well and good, but no matter how strong you might be, you’re still human. Don’t neglect a whole part of who you are out of fear or guilt. Besides, the next fellow to fancy you likely won’t be as dauntless as I am, so your rebuffing might actually hurt.”

“I’ll do my best.” Owen kept his tone neutral, but the conversation had definitely stirred up questions he’d been avoiding. To say nothing of the fact that Jeremiah was right: he was trying to do nothing but live the job. How many rookies had he watched burn themselves out like that? And what made him think he’d be any different when he’d already folded once before?



“I suppose that will have to suffice,” Jeremiah said, breaking Owen out of his thought spiral. “At least until I think the time is right to ask you out properly.”

## 53.

It was getting late in the evening by the time Owen finally made it back to the building's massive penthouse that he'd begun to think of as home. True to his word, Jeremiah had shifted down the over-the-top advances and focused on delivering pertinent information about the robot attacks. There hadn't been anything groundbreaking, but that was to be expected at this point. If those running down the leads found anything juicy, there would have been a call to action, even if Owen wasn't included on it.

Still, the food had been excellent, and Jeremiah was right about the quality of the restaurant's craft beers. Overall it would have been a pleasant night out if not for the whole awkwardness of the dinner's beginning.

Owen tried not to dwell on said awkwardness, or on how right Jeremiah might have been, as he walked through the front door. Most of the lights were out, save for a small one in the kitchen and the massive glow thrown by the television screen. On it, a virtual character in a skimpy outfit was striking an overly-muscled man with her sword. It only took Owen a few seconds to recognize the male character, and the moment he did, a long groan escaped his mouth.

"Really? You found a copy of a *Hero Team Battle Force 5*? Lenny swore to me that they'd stopped making new copies of it years ago."

"Yeah, welcome to the age of the internet," Hexcellent said, maneuvering her scarcely-clad character around the battlefield, blade still in hand as the avatar slashed away at Virtual Titan's health bar. "Someone put up all the games forever ago, and people have been tossing on their own mods as well. It took me less than five minutes to get this baby hooked up."

Owen just shook his head as he saw the pixelated version of himself go into an animated death swoon. It seemed Hexcellent was pretty good for having just downloaded the game: Titan was one of the boss characters. It had been specified in his contract.

"I'm going to bed," he announced.

"Aw, don't be like that. Grab a controller and show me if you can make your avatar kick as much ass as you did the other day." Hexcellent held up a spare controller, and to his surprise, Owen walked over and picked it up.

He'd never been much for arcade games, but right now doing anything besides marinating in his own thoughts seemed appealing.

"Awesome, now A is punch, B is kick. . ." Hexcellent continued explaining the controls to him, then gave Owen a few minutes to practice before they started their first battle. The two round match lasted less than thirty seconds.

"You are not great at this," Hexcellent said, clicking the button to start a rematch.

"Give me a break, I literally just started playing."

Hexcellent laughed softly, a sound more personal and delicate than the showy boisterous chuckles she put on when the crowd was around. "No, I'm actually kind of glad you suck. I was starting to wonder if there was anything you weren't impossibly good at."

"Trust me, I'm bad at loads of things," Owen assured her.

"Really? Not from where I'm sitting. You stroll in here out of the past and proceed to pretty much kick ass at everything you do. You saved a girl on your first night here, and then went out of your way to make sure she was taken care of. You get a call about some incoming robots that took down a whole Hero team and you smash them to pieces. The minute you start dealing with the media again it's all they can do to stop talking about you, and yesterday you took down the top Hero team in this whole fucking city. So far this is the first thing I've seen that you really blow at." To illustrate the point, Hexcellent delivered a killing strike, finishing the first round of their rematch.

"Well, I've also managed to act like an ass when I first arrived and piss off our boss multiple times, not to mention alienate one or two members of the team. I'm clearly not great at this job."

"Look, Zone's stuff is his own. He's not dumb; he understands that even if you'd played things a different way there's no guarantee things would have been easier on his brother. He's just pissed at how things went, and you're the only tangible thing he can point at and blame. Sooner or later he'll get over it. But who is the other person you think you've alienated?"

"Bubble Bubble seems largely indifferent to my presence," Owen admitted.

"Oh, yeah, she is, but that's true for all of us. B.B. isn't exactly what

you'd call a team player. She tries not to get attached; makes moving about easier on her. I tried a lot to connect with her when she first joined but she was having none of it. Now I mostly just trade insults with her. I like to think it's affectionate, but even I'm not totally sure at this point."

The digital version of Titan began his final death animation again as Hexcellent's blade-wielder took him down. Before Owen could object, she'd clicked on the rematch button and a new battle was beginning.

"I guess it's reassuring, in a way, to know that she at least acts the same toward everyone," Owen said.

"Yup, total ice queen. Don't let it get you down. For what it's worth, I'm really glad you joined our team. It's kind of neat, having a legendary Hero with us. Instead of just being the dorky corpies, we get to see what it's like around the cool kids. Plus, you know, you aren't so terrible as a person either."

Owen smiled, attacking with his character and being summarily driven back by Hexcellent's superior skills. "I think you're easily the coolest kids I've dealt with since getting back. But honestly, if you ever wanted to go Hero, you've easily got enough power to get into the program."

"I appreciate it, but they don't let people with my kind of criminal record in the HCP," Hexcellent said. "Trust me, I tried every last one of them before I took this job."

"Oh." Owen had been wondering almost since he arrived why this powerful, courageous, tenacious young woman had opted for private response instead of trying to be a Hero. This made sense, though; having a criminal record was almost always an automatic rejection from the HCP. She would have needed someone to really take an interest in her to get offered a shot, and even then it still might not have happened. "Sorry, I didn't mean to--"

"Relax, I know you meant it as a compliment," Hexcellent assured him, killing his avatar for the sixth straight time and ending their third match. "When I was young I got caught up with the wrong crowd. A few years and a drug addiction later I finally hit rock bottom and decided to clean my life up, but it didn't change what I'd done. There's a price for fucking up that badly; my chances at an HCP career were a part of it."

She held up her controller and glanced over to Owen. "Want to scamper off to bed, or are you itching for more of this sweet, sweet punishment?"

Owen regarded her for a moment, impressed by her maturity. Most people couldn't own their demons like that. They had to push off what they'd done onto circumstances or others. She'd taken her responsibility without hesitation, and Owen found his respect for her growing yet again. It truly was a shame she'd taken a bad road; he thought the world would have benefited from Hexcellent the Hero.

"I'm down for a few more matches, but I'd like to switch characters first," Owen said. "Between you and me, this Titan guy kind of sucks."

## 54.

After the battle with Elemental Fury, things in Brewster grew quiet. It was a peace that left Owen on edge, the sort of thing he never really trusted. Even so, the sudden arrival of chaos only took him off guard because it came while he was unconscious.

When the alarm yanked Owen forcefully from sleep, he very nearly destroyed the floor in his attempts to get out of bed. For a split second his muddled brain forgot every change that it had undergone in the last two decades. Instead of being roused to help with a rescue or cleanup effort, Owen's head was screaming that he was in his old base and that they were under attack.

He slammed his feet through the carpet and into the concrete so hard that the force left nearly perfect footprints. It was only when he reached for his mask, which should be resting on the bedside stand, and found nothing more than a desk lamp and a picture, that Owen finally pulled himself out of the fugue and realized where he was. Years of training was good most of the time, but on occasion it outlived its usefulness.

As he pulled on his costume and tried to think of a way to hide the cracked floor lest Greene charge him for it, Galvanize's voice came over the intercom system. Owen nearly didn't recognize it, however, as the young leader's voice was filled with something he'd never heard there before. Galvanize, the calm rock of their chaotic team, was doing all he could to fight back panic.

"This is an all hands situation, repeat, all hands. Anyone not downstairs in five minutes will be left behind, but will be expected to find their own way to the scene as soon as possible. The I-287 overpass in North Brewster was severely damaged in a fight between a criminal Super and Heroes. Current estimates put at least two hundred cars stranded in deteriorating positions with civilians blocked in by debris. The fight caused damage in several other areas as well, so resources are stretched thin. We are needed, people. *Now.*"

Owen took a deep breath, then slapped the rest of his costume on so quickly that he nearly ripped it in half twice. That overpass stretched across a large area of residential housing, which meant they needed to evacuate the

people under it just as much as the ones on top of it. Depending on who else was there, they might be able to help prop the thing up, but with thin resources, odds were they had to race the clock.

Tearing out of his room as fast as he could go, Owen dashed down the hall, through the living room, and just made it to the elevator as Bubble Bubble saw him coming and held the door. He sprinted through it, barely stopping before he slammed into the back wall, and heard the oddly inappropriate gentle ding as the elevator began lowering them to the basement.

“We’re the last ones,” Bubble Bubble informed him. Unlike Galvanize, she had not lost her seemingly infinite amount of quiet composure.

“How do you know?”

“Hexcellent was up playing video games; I saw her paused screen when I left the living room. Galvanize would have gotten the word before any of us and therefore been prepping to go. As for Zone, he prides himself on his speed and reflexes. Losing to either of us would be a point of wounded honor for him.”

Owen nodded, watching as the red digital numbers ticked away, marking their descent. It struck him as curious that as much as Hexcellent seemed to think Bubble Bubble wasn’t interested in team, the red-haired young woman appeared to have a keen eye for details and a strong grasp of her teammates’ habits. At any other time, it would have been something he dug deeper on, but as the elevator slowed, all he could think of was the situation demanding their aid. It wouldn’t be until much later that Owen realized this marked the first occasion when he looked at the problem as a PEERS first and a Hero second.

Perhaps that was why it wasn’t until he’d leapt into the SUV and slammed his door shut that he finally remembered to touch his right ear and get a full assessment of the situation. Before he had the chance, however, Galvanize began to fill them in.

“There was an attempted murder roughly twenty-five minutes ago, over in North Brewster.” Galvanize’s foot didn’t leave the pedal as he spoke. The siren’s muffled roar could be heard overhead. “Some gang’s strongman was sent to take out a rival gang’s leader. We don’t know if the first gang was dumb, or just working off bad information, but their guy never stood a chance. The target was a fellow Super, an energy manipulator whose energy

had highly corrosive properties.”

Owen winced inwardly. Energy manipulators were bad enough; those with talent could create all manner of constructs or obstacles to utilize. Some of the really gifted ones could even coat themselves in their energy, like a suit of armor. If the energy itself destroyed most matter it came into contact with that upped the destructive potential considerably. Just from knowing those two facts, Owen would estimate that sort of opponent to be a Demolition Class, minimum.

“The fight drew the right kind of attention, and a team of Heroes stepped in,” Galvanize continued. “I don’t know the details, but they were able to bring him down. Unfortunately, he doled out a lot of damage on his way to getting killed. Right now, every emergency service that can is scrambling to get the people to safety.”

“What about the Heroes who stopped this guy?” Zone asked. “Aren’t they helping?”

“The ones who can are currently containing and evacuating a section of the city he managed to partially cave in to the sewers,” Galvanize snapped. He paused for a moment, and Owen watched him carefully. The rise and fall of his chest betrayed the deep breaths he was taking, no doubt in an attempt to keep an even keel. “Some are getting healed; they’ll jump in wherever they can. We don’t have time to play jurisdiction jockeying right now. Once we get there, it’s going to be a madhouse. Follow my orders as best you can, but put protecting the civilians first above all else. Everyone clear?”

The vehicle’s passengers all nodded, too well-trained to try and talk over one another while their leader was giving direction. Galvanize appreciated them all the more for it. He pulled up to the boundaries of a massive traffic jam, the sun’s early morning rays glinting off the metal tops of seemingly countless stopped cars. They were going to need every bit of that discipline to pull off the sort of miracle they needed to.

“Good, then this is where we get out. Everyone, please do your best. Lives depend on it.”



Titan had seen worse.

He'd come upon battlegrounds after Armageddon Class Supers were taken down. He'd seen entire streets run thick with blood and bodies, the latter often wearing masks that he recognized. He'd seen what happened when Heroes were too slow, when civilians were piled like kindling after a maniac's rampage. He'd seen truly horrible things in his time as a Hero, the sort that woke him in a cold sweat some nights, desperately groping for someone nearby to remind him that it was going to be okay. As he surveyed the scene before him, he did so with a sense of perspective, and concluded that the situation was bad, but not horrible. Of course, all of that perspective just lit a fire in his gut, driving him to make sure this morning didn't turn into another one that would live on for decades in his nightmares.

The overpass was badly damaged; part of it had been sheared off completely and several of the support columns were broken. Since it was a flyover that stretched across a residential area, bits of the debris had already come down and crushed several houses. Titan dearly hoped they'd been evacuated first, then immediately put it out of his mind. It was key to focus on the people he could still help, not dwell on the ones already lost. That was how he'd keep himself moving if things took a turn for the terrible.

A massive jam of cars stretched before him, most of which were already emptied. The impromptu parking lot stretched up to the section of the overpass where at least a dozen vehicles had been flipped and scattered, creating an unintentional barricade for all the civilians still stuck on the elevated concrete. Some of the cars had caught fire, which meant he had to worry about the slim, but still real, chance of a gas tank exploding on top of everything else. It was bad, but not hopeless.

"Hexcellent, I want Huggles on that overpass. Reports show some people trapped in their cars; get them out now. When that's done, help clear the debris. Zone, you and Bubble Bubble start evacuating people from the broken end of the bridge. She can only take so many at a time, which means you have to keep the order between trips. Titan, I want that wall of cars cleared out, at least enough to make a path that I can lead people through. Be careful, but be quick. B.B. might have to chip in on helping keep the overpass up, which will make your exit point the only one we can use. I'm going to

help Hexcellent and Huggles get people out of cars and try to organize them as best I can. This is a fluid situation, so be ready to change in a moment if needed.”

Galvanize didn’t waste any more time with words; instead he took off at a dead sprint through the sea of empty cars that led up to the barricade, the others hot on his heels.

Titan was with them, moving carefully to avoid knocking one of the vehicles aside and causing a domino effect. By this point, he was used to the precise way that Galvanize deployed his team, but he was still impressed by it. In his Hero days, he’d have never imagined a team purely devoted to rescue would require such careful coordination; several weeks actually doing the job had shown him how essential it was. More than once it had made the difference in saving someone’s life, which meant it was a skill damned sure worth having.

They all reached the barricade at roughly the same time, though Zone started moving over it first. He leapt up the pile of shattered concrete and twisted auto parts, only needing a single sphere from Bubble Bubble to finish his climb. Hexcellent and Galvanize waited as Bubble Bubble produced an orb that engulfed them and soon began its slow, but steady, trek over to the other side. Her ability wasn’t quick, though it was certainly useful.

For his part, Titan wasted no time once his team was clear. Surveying the warped barricade with an experienced eye, he looked for the spot that could most easily be turned into an opening. He’d have to be choosy, since he had very limited space to accommodate whatever he moved. Add that to the slope of stopped cars descending behind him and it would be all too easy to start a steel avalanche. That meant either just shifting the vehicles or having to try and stack them, both of which had their cons.

With a slam of his shoulder, Titan grabbed the nearest car by its axle and pulled it forward, moving slowly so as not to send the rest of the debris tumbling uncontrolled in all directions. It was akin to playing a very high stakes game of *Jenga*, and as he felt several other cars shudder, Titan would have traded two tons of lifting power for the ability to disintegrate matter. Thankfully, the barricade held, and he squeezed the first car into an open spot near two sports cars. It was a start, but there was still a lot to clear away before he could escort anyone without super-human endurance through it.

“Titan, this is Dispatch.” He heard the voice in his ear as he hefted up a slab of concrete and dropped it unceremoniously on the first car, smashing

out the one remaining window but otherwise doing little to the already-battered automobile.

“Dispatch is heard, Titan responding.”

“Titan, you are currently showing in the recently damaged North Brewster area on a rescue operation, and your PEERS team shows as present too. Is that accurate?”

“Sure is,” Titan said. He tried to ignore the growing knot of worry in his stomach. If she was checking everyone’s position, not just Heroes, then it meant something bad.

“That zone has been reclassified from contained to active,” Dispatch said. He wondered how she could stay so calm, even in moments like these. Maybe that was her ability, wherever she was. “The gangs involved in the initial dispute have begun fighting in the streets. Based on information at hand, we have at least four confirmed Supers, with many more suspected. PEERS teams are permitted to remain and continue evacuating civilians at the discretion of their Hero Liaisons, but all active Heroes in the area are to focus on containing the brawl before more destruction occurs.”

Titan let out a long breath as he lowered the car clutched in his hands. Supers fighting in an area already on the brink of destruction meant lives were hanging in the balance. He released the car and looked around, trying to spot where the fight might be going down.

“Give me coordinates, Dispatch. And what’s the containment protocol on this one?”

“With so many civilians already in danger nearby, the DVA has ordered that Damage Class evaluation protocol be temporarily suspended. First priority is neutralization before any more innocent lives are lost. The lives of aggressors are considered low-priority.”

“Understood,” Titan said, and he did understand. In a perfect world, the Heroes could stop people without having to resort to lethal force, but some Supers just wouldn’t go down unless it was in a permanent fashion. It was messy, and hard, and ugly; but it was better than letting innocent people pay the price instead.

Titan listened to the coordinates Dispatch rattled off in his head, then he began to run.



## 56.

“Team, I need everyone’s positions. Now.” Titan tapped his left earpiece as he ran, wedging it back into place. Unlike his Hero one, this radio hadn’t been tweaked and updated by every tech-genius to have to worn one in the last several decades, and as such it didn’t quite sit nestled in his ear with the same ease.

“Little busy.” Zone’s voice sounded like a forced whisper, as though he under tremendous physical strain.

“As Hero Liaison I am informing you that we have a hostile situation with multiple rogue Supers, and I need to assess if your position is safe or not. Now sound off, and hurry up with it.” Were there more time, Titan might have bothered with diplomacy, but time wasn’t extending him such luxuries. He had skulls to crack, and it would be a lot easier to fight if he knew his people were clear.

“Holy shit,” Hexcellent muttered in his ear. “Um, yeah, Galvanize and I are on the overpass; right now he’s pulling people free while Huggles cuts off the back of their car. We’re about halfway between the barricade and the part that’s just open air where B.B. is evacuating people.”

“Confirmed,” Galvanize grunted, clearly occupied with his rescue effort.

“I’m lowering my second batch of people to the ground now,” Bubble Bubble chimed in. “Once we land, I’m sending them west, where police and ambulances are waiting on standby.”

“That’s all fine, the disturbance is to the northeast, and I plan to make sure it stays out there,” Titan told them. “But you should be ready to move if-”

“Hang on, you said it’s to the northeast?” Bubble Bubble asked. “Northeast of where the collapsed portion of the overpass is?”

“Affirmative.”

“That’s not good. We had a kid in the first batch of rescues get confused and run off in that direction. Zone went to retrieve her, and he hasn’t come back yet.”

Titan realized he hadn't heard anything from Zone since he'd made what Titan had taken to be a snide comment. When he replayed the words in his head, he wondered if perhaps there had been furtiveness in Zone's whisper, as if their missing teammate were trying to speak without calling attention to himself. Then he remembered that Zone, like all the other PEERS, wore a damn costume, which an angry criminal wouldn't realize wasn't on an actual Hero.

"Zone," he called into the earpiece, picking up his pace. "Zone, if you are near the conflict, I need to know. That spot is about to get very hot, very fast, and every Hero dropping in is expecting civilians to be out. Give me some sort of sign, even if it risks you being discovered."

"We're here." This time the words were so thin that Titan wouldn't have heard them at all if he weren't specifically listening for them. He bounded across a street; already he could faintly make out the sounds of fighting going on. It had been a rough situation before. Now, it was downright horrid.

"Understood," Titan said. He stopped his charge a block away from the coordinates Dispatch had provided. Once he was in, things would be sheer chaos, which meant all plans needed to be laid out before he entered the fray. "When you say 'we,' I assume that means you have the child with you. You should see me in less than a minute, and I'm pretty sure that everyone there is going to care a lot more about me than you. If you can get clear, do it, and let me know as you go. If you can't, then get to me. I'll keep you safe."

There was no response this time. . . not that Titan was particularly surprised. Whatever was happening a mere block away was more than enough to keep Zone, one of the team's most mobile members, completely pinned down. It was certainly a shitshow, and since Titan couldn't suppress it fast enough to get people clear, he'd just slap himself into the center of the storm.

With a mighty burst of power from his legs, Titan leapt up onto the roof of the nearest building, carefully controlling his landing to avoid anything more serious than a few damaged shingles. He'd barely set down before he was in the sky again, heading for higher ground. As the air whistled by him, he spoke, trusting his communicator to pick up the words.

"Dispatch, this is Titan. I'm about to begin engagement, but there's a civilian and a member of my team pinned down somewhere in it. If there are any other Heroes in the area, please let them know."

“We’ve got two more en route; I’ll brief them on the situation. Currently, you will be the first to arrive,” Dispatch informed him.

“Well then, at least I get to make my entrance as showy as I want.” He landed on the third building, a four-story number composed of lifeless gray brick. It was an apartment complex, one in which he imagined all the residents were locking their doors and calling the cops. From its roof, he could see the fight below; several people still scrapping while others were motionless in puddles of blood. The brawl had probably started in the alleyway and then spilled into the street as things grew more frantic. Titan saw one man hurling bolts of gray energy, another taking gunfire without so much as a wince, and a third zipping about in a blur. Two others had shifted into quasi-animal forms that looked like a bear and a boar, respectively. The rest probably had some abilities as well, but Titan couldn’t loaf around and wait to see what they were. He needed to get a handle on this situation, and fast.

The whistling sound reached a few of the more attentive criminal’s ears first. It came less than a second before impact, however, which meant even if the bullet-proof thug had taken the time to look up at the noise, it was unlikely that he would have had time to dodge. As it was, he didn’t even see the several-hundred-pound mass that landed on his shoulders and shattered the bones that had born countless attempts at injury as easily as dry spaghetti. The thug let out a strangled cry from the ground, which was heard by almost no one, as all attention was on the massive man who had just dropped out of the air and taken out the toughest person left in either gang. This mystery man took two steps forward and spoke in a booming voice that echoed through the streets like a bomb’s aftershock.

“My name is Titan—yes, *that* fucking Titan—and the next person who moves to do anything besides get on the ground will be broken.”

For a moment, the gangs looked at one another, uncertain of what to do. They had, after all, been fighting each other. Eventually, survival instinct manifested, and all present realized that the Hero was easily the greater threat. Every last one of them charged, and Titan readied himself to make good on his word.

What Titan had entered in with Elemental Fury was a fight. It required strategy, restraint, planning, and cunning all piled on top of his already-impressive physical abilities. Titan was good at fighting; it was why he'd been able to take down such powerful enemies in the past. He enjoyed a good fight, but what followed after the two gangs merged into a single force dedicated to bringing him down was nothing like a fight. It was a brawl.

Even after all these years, Titan could still feel the adrenaline surging through his veins as he stared down over a dozen opponents, all coming at him together. His fingers tingled. Time began to feel a bit slippery. When it was over, he wouldn't remember many of the fine details. Those would be lost in a sea of snapping bones and anguished screams. But as it was happening, Titan took in everything without exception.

As he grabbed the bear-shifter's arm and snapped it in half, he could smell the man's cologne when he fell, hitting the ground with a painful thud. When Titan caught the speedster's clumsy punch, he noticed the young boy's nose piercings just before he drove a foot down and shattered those speedy legs. At the moment that three of the gang members leapt on his back, he caught sight of their terrified but determined faces in one of the few unshattered windows on the street. That moment would stay with him, making him wonder if there was a better way than coming in full force. He almost hesitated, then he remembered that Zone and a child were somewhere in the area trying to stay safe. Titan's resolve hardened. As he stripped each person from his back and hurled them into the concrete wall, he tried to keep from killing them, but he made certain that none would be rising anytime soon.

A bolt of gray energy hit Titan's side, and he glanced up to see the culprit staring at him, eyes wide with surprise. Evidently, he'd been expecting a different result. Either these punks didn't watch the news or they didn't believe the hype. Those that survived sure as hell would from here on, though.

It was funny: all the money and time spent on PR by Heroes and their agents, yet nothing spread true fear in a Hero's opponents like being in the middle of a Hero's path of destruction.



Titan closed the gap to the blaster, knocking aside a pair of men in leather jackets who tried to take a swing at him. He reared back, ready to put the young man down, but a gust of wind made Titan suddenly aware of a hole in the side of costume where the energy had hit him. It was perfect erosion: no shredded cloth or scorched material. Titan let his battle-drunk brain work for a moment, remembering the original report he'd been given about a dead Super with corrosion energy, and noticing how this fellow had puffy circles around his eyes, as if he'd been crying. Supers weren't inherently more likely to have Super children, but those in the same family often had somewhat similar abilities.

Instead of punching him in the head, which could potentially result in brain death even if he was only aiming for a knockout, Titan shattered the man's legs, leaving him to howl in the street. Technically the kid could still use his powers, but without HCP-grade training, it was unlikely he'd be able to focus through the pain. If he did, then Titan would finish the job, but it felt wrong to kill someone who was acting out of grief more than anger. At least, not without giving them a chance.

The effortless defeat of their energy blaster seemed to have broken some of the criminals' spirit, as they now looked at Titan with a new sense of awe and dread. They'd clearly thought that he'd be taken down by one good shot. Faced with the reality of a Titan utterly uninjured by what was presumably their most powerful remaining offense, their willpower began to fracture and break. Several dashed away, running for the alley where the fight had started.

"Goddamnit! I just stepped out and I've got a fucking wave coming at me," Zone panted frantically in Titan's left ear, no longer bothering to whisper.

There was no time to think, no opportunity to concoct some cunning plan. The span of seconds it would take would likely mean the difference of life and death for Zone, to say nothing of the child in his care. Spinning in the direction of the runners, Titan could see Zone and a young girl in his arms, halfway emerged from under a pile of trash in the alley. In front of those two were five fleeing criminals, one of whom was the shifter in boar form. Zone was standing directly in their way. If the gang hit his teammate and the civilian, especially knowing Titan was at their backs, chances of casualties were high, if not completely certain.

Pressing his boot into the concrete so hard that cracks spiderwebbed

out from under it, Titan pushed off in a charging leap. He stayed low: the goal this time wasn't to get a better location, it was to play human bowling with himself as the ball. Arms spread out wide to catch all that he could, Titan hurtled through the air, slamming into four of the five would-be-escapees with such force that he could feel their bones break as he made contact. Just before he was about to come to a stop, he twisted in midair so that his back hit a nearby brick building before the four already-battered bodies clutched in his arms. Titan let them drop to the ground; now that they were gone, he had a more important target.

The shifter was still getting up from the ground where he'd thrown himself to avoid Titan's charge when the Hero stepped forward, putting himself firmly between Zone and the boar. A pair of piggy eyes darted back and forth, locking on Zone, or perhaps the child crying in his arms, and lingering there for a moment. Titan could practically see the wheels turning, trying to figure out if he could get there fast enough to take a hostage.

"Ah ah ah." Titan wagged his finger in the air, drawing the boar's gaze back to him. "You'll never make it. And if you try, I'm going to be less gentle than I have been with your friends. A *lot* less gentle."

"Maybe so," the boar-man snorted. "But I bet one of us will make it."

"You want to know one of the most important rules in battle, BeBop? Always be aware of your surroundings. And maybe you should have noticed that I'm no longer the only Hero on the scene."

The pigman quickly turned around, barely getting a chance to see the new uniforms tearing through his fellow gang members and enemies before he felt a powerful hand grip him by the collarbone.

"Another good rule in battle: don't take your eyes off the fucking enemy."

Titan was quick with crippling the shifter, and luckily the criminal quickly passed out from the pain of his broken limbs. That attended to, Titan jogged back over to Zone and the young girl.

"You should be clear now. Get her to safety and then rendezvous with the team. I have to keep helping clean up here."

"No problem," Zone said, slightly readjusting his grip on the sobbing girl. "And thanks for the assist."

“That’s what teammates do,” Titan replied, turning back to the fray still going on.

“Also, why the hell did you call that guy Bebop?”

“Didn’t watch many cartoons as a kid, I take it?” Titan shook his head and allowed himself a small laugh, despite the horror of the day so far. “I’ll explain when things are done.”

“Good enough for me.”

Zone darted off, racing through the alleyway and back toward what one could only hope would be safety. Unfortunately, unless someone else had shown up to unblock the bridge, that area was also a rapidly deteriorating situation waiting to turn into a tragedy.

Titan scanned the scene, noting that a Hero in blue shooting white fire and one who had shifted into a ten-foot-tall spiny creature had picked off most of the stragglers. As he looked, his eyes fell on a fallen, weeping form, and an idea surfaced in the sea of his thoughts.

“Dispatch, I need you to patch me in to a DVA representative. I may have a way to help our overpass situation, but I’m going to have to make some promises.”

## 58.

Titan crouched down by the young man with the shattered legs. This kid wasn't the only one with such injuries dotting the fractured city street. The legs were the best place to go for, usually. It made it impossible to run away, crippled mobility, and put people in too much pain to focus enough to use their abilities. Titan had broken more legs than he could count in his years wearing the mask, and as such had become reasonably adept at gauging the severity of a wound just from looking at it.

"It'll heal," he said, drawing the young man's attention to his presence. "Not well, mind you, but it will heal in the sense that you'll have two legs. You might be able to get around without a wheelchair, if you don't skimp on physical therapy, though your days of running marathons are pretty much a thing of the past."

"Fuck you," the criminal grunted from the ground.

"Now now, I'm not saying all this to be cruel. We've got a healer currently heading to this area to patch up people hurt in the overpass accident, the one your. . . I'm going to guess brother. . . caused."

The criminal looked up from the concrete for the first time, his still-red eyes widening as he locked met Titan's gaze. "How did you know?"

"The reports from the fight said the energy projector had a corrosive property. Your attack burned through my costume in less than a second, and these things are made of pretty sturdy material. It seemed like a reasonable guess that two men in the same gang with similar powers were related. Let me guess: you both got the same energy type, just one as a projector and one as a blaster."

"My brother and I have. . . *had* the same energy." His eyes darkened, and Titan could practically see the resolve building as he tried to gather up enough focus for another attack.

Titan reached down and flicked the young man on his earlobe.

"Ow!" The young man rubbed his ear, all focus scattered in the brief shock of pain.

"Listen. . . I'm sorry, I never got your name. I'm Titan, in case you

missed it the first time.”

The greeting was met by a hard, sullen stare.

“Giving me your name isn’t going to get you any more in trouble than you already are, and it will make it easier for me to try and dig you some of the way out of this shit heap. I understand you’re upset about your brother, but you have to at least partly realize that this was something he brought upon himself. So you can lie here, be pissed, then go to jail and live with hobbled legs for the rest of your life, or you can hear me out and see if you might like what I’m selling before turning me down. You’ve already seen what’s behind door number two, why not at least take a peek behind number one?”

He kept on staring, and Titan shifted his weight, preparing to get up. As he moved a single word slipped out of the young criminal’s mouth. “Eli.”

“That’s progress,” Titan said. “Listen, Eli: right now there is a very rare, once in a lifetime opportunity sitting before you. We need to get people off that overpass as quickly as possible, and your power could make that happen. And we’re prepared to compensate you for it.”

Eli snorted. “My power can’t help anyone. All I do is destroy stuff.”

“Today that’s exactly what we need. The Super world is a funny place; you never know which ability will save the day. This time, it’s yours, so be grateful. Few people ever get the chance to really make a difference.”

“You want me to just forget about the fact that you all killed my brother, and that you broke my damn legs into pieces? You and all those Heroes can go fuck yourselves.”

Titan leaned back a touch, a feat that was actually quite impressive in his crouched position. “Honestly, I don’t blame you for that sentiment. If the tables were turned, I’d probably feel the same way. But there’s a flaw in your logic, Eli. Those people stuck out there aren’t Heroes. They’re just regular folks. Families going to work or school who got caught up in a battle of beings that exist on a scale they can’t even comprehend. Now when I look at all the bodies that were dropped around here, I don’t see any with big corroded holes in them. That tells me that you, Eli, are not a killer. Even when you shot at me, you went for the side, an attack that would injure but probably not kill. Maybe I’m wrong and you don’t mind letting dozens of innocent people die out of spite, but I don’t think I am. I don’t think you want all that blood on your hands. But make no mistake: if you do nothing and let people die, you will feel the weight of their loss for the rest of your life. Trust me.”

“It’s your job to help people, not mine,” Eli protested.

“It’s everyone’s job to help people. I just get to do it on a bigger scale. Today, so can you.”

Eli stayed silent for a long moment, before pushing himself up a few more inches. “You’ll fix my legs?”

“We’ll have to. You’re going to need your focus for what’s ahead,” Titan told him.

“What about jail?”

“Like I said, it’s pretty obvious you didn’t kill anyone, so that’s in your favor. I’ve already gotten word from the DVA that if you’re willing to pitch in on saving those people, they’re willing to be lenient on you. You may even be able to get on some sort of work release; there’s bound to be plenty of people who could use your abilities. And on top of all of that, I’ll personally speak on your behalf if your case goes to trial. I might not be the most popular Hero around anymore, but people tend to listen when we say someone isn’t beyond saving. So you tell me, Eli, are you too far gone?”

“N. . . no. I’ll take the deal. Patch me up then show me what you want destroyed.”

“Wonderful. Oh, and Eli, this probably goes without saying, but I’ll say it anyway: if you try and double-cross me or hurt anyone, I’ll break a lot more than your legs.”

“You’re right, it did go without saying,” Eli replied.

“Glad to hear. Dispatch, this is Titan. I need Fix-It brought to my location as soon as possible. We’ve got a way to get this situation under control.”

## 59.

“Get everyone back from the debris,” Titan ordered into his comm. It had taken longer than he wanted to meet up with Fix-It then get back to the barrier of cars and concrete, but he’d finally arrived with a freshly-healed Eli in tow. The young man had borne the journey better than others that Titan had leapt around with before, though his skin was slightly blanched as Titan set him back onto solid ground.

“Heard,” Galvanize replied. “Pulling back as far as we can safely go. What’s the ETA on opening up a way out for us? Reports from below say they won’t be able to keep the overpass suspended much longer. Supers are pretty much the only things keeping us aloft right now.”

“If this works, then we should have a clear path in less than a minute. If not, I’m going to have to be sloppy in opening up a hole.”

“I’ll cross my fingers for Plan A,” Galvanize replied.

While they’d been talking, Eli had walked up and down the length of the barrier, assessing which places to target first. Titan kept a close eye on the kid, watching for any sign that he was thinking about running. Thankfully, Eli was either a man of his word or he was smart enough to know that Titan wouldn’t let him go; regardless, he made no movement to bolt. Instead, he turned back to the man who had beaten, crippled, and then helped fix him all in the span of less than half an hour.

“I’m going to try and start around the black sedan,” Eli said, pointing to an area thick with car parts and concrete.

“Seems like it will take longer to get through there.” Titan didn’t contradict the assessment; he merely waited to see how Eli would justify it.

“Only a bit, and it’s far more stable than some of the other parts. If I get rid of a different section, it will cause another piece of the wall to come tumbling down. This is the only area that seems solid enough to carve a path through.”

“Then go to it,” Titan instructed. He’d reached much the same conclusion when he first assessed the problem; it was interesting that Eli had a keen enough eye to spot the potential hazards. Then again, for a kid whose

ability eroded matter into nothingness, that was probably something he'd needed to master out of sheer self-preservation.

Eli raised his hands toward the chunk of barricade and took a deep breath. Gray, crackling energy manifested in his palms. Twin orbs steadily grew until they were roughly the size of softballs. The one from his right palm flew forward, washing over the front door of the sedan and quickly vanishing, along with most of the door.

"Going to have to go bigger," Eli muttered to himself. The orb in his left hand began expanding, filling with more power until it was bigger than a basketball and barely fit in Eli's grip. This time when the orb struck the debris, it wiped out the rest of the sedan and a large chunk of concrete behind it.

"All right, that's the size." Eli's hands filled with two more orbs, more quickly this time than the first. He fired both shots in short order, quickly destroying a vast chunk of the barricade. Titan could already see through to the other side; there were only cursory obstacles left in place.

"Tone it down for the next shot," Titan cautioned, which earned him a contemptuous glare from Eli.

"I know how to use my power." Eli demonstrated just that by lobbing two smaller orbs at the remaining debris, opening up a path to the other side with unexpected precision. Before Titan could comment, Eli charged up another pair of shots and went to the task of widening his hole in the barricade so more people could fit through.

"Galvanize, we're got an opening. Bring everyone this way, but keep them orderly. This is still a dangerous area if things get out of control."

"Don't worry, Huggles is really good at making people stay in line," Hexcellent replied.

"True, though I won't be surprised if at least a few parents try to bill us for the therapy their children will doubtlessly need," Galvanize replied. "Hexcellent is heading to your location. I'm going to hang back and make sure everyone gets through."

"We'll be waiting here to guide them along," Titan said. He looked around, trying to see any early arrivals through the newly opened hole, and noticed that Eli had stopped shooting orbs.



“This is as big as I can get it without risking another section spilling over,” the young criminal said.

“Then it’s what we’ve got to work with.” Titan scanned the path; it was large enough for him to stand comfortably in, though he couldn’t raise his arms from his sides without smacking debris. It would be a deathtrap if the people panicked, but with Huggles around, hopefully they would be more scared of the blade-armed demon than the tenuous safety of their surroundings.

“So is this it? Did I earn my freedom?”

“You earned your legs,” Titan shot back, motioning to the functioning limbs that had been crushed bone fifteen minutes ago. “I’ll hold up my end as far as talking to the cops like I promised, but there’s no way you’re going to skate out of this completely scot-free.”

“Worth a shot,” Eli said, allowing himself a defeated shrug.

“Don’t get too down. You’re in a much better position than you were when I snapped your legs and you were lying in the street. If nothing else, you just helped save people. That matters. . . at least it should to you.”

Their conversation was interrupted by the rumble of dozens of voices. Civilians were trudging across what remained of the overpass, heading toward the gateway to safety that Eli had managed to open up before. Titan stepped forward, waving his arms so that people could see where to head.

“Stay close, and be good,” Titan said. “We’ve still got a lot of people to help before this morning is over.”

The sun was halfway through the sky before the situation was officially considered stabilized. After clearing off the civilians, the weakened and tottering overpass was finally allowed to collapse. Several of the Heroes who'd been using their efforts to keep it aloft did the same, mentally or physically strained by the considerable effort. Sadly, the end of the bridge did not mark the end of the day, as there were still hundreds of vehicles stuck on a road going nowhere, all of which had to be turned around and rerouted. Every Super who could still work pitched in, some going so far as to physically lift cars with passengers still inside and take them to another street. A few days later a picture of Titan carrying a sedan on each shoulder would surface, a single still snapped by a fortunate photographer. As the morning finally came to a close, however, none of the responders were thinking about pictures or press. They were all just exhausted. Even the ones whose bodies rebuked such sentiments could feel the weariness in their minds.

"Team," Galvanize called through their earpieces, gathering their collective attention. "I just got word that the last stranded civilian has been relocated. What follows is a lot of cleanup and debris removal, but our team is being released with the city's thanks. Meet back at the SUV and let's go home."

His people didn't need any more encouragement than that as they made their way across the concrete dusted landscape over broken bits or homes or cars. It was a depressing place to walk through, made better only by the fact that each Super knew that it would have been much worse if they hadn't been there. Houses could be rebuilt, cars replaced, overpasses reconstructed. Those people who'd been trapped, on the other hand, were each one of a kind. While everyone was spent in some capacity, it was the good kind of worn out, the sort that came with a sense of accomplishment.

"Where's your little buddy?" Hexcellent asked Titan as they arrived at the car. It had been moved more than once on Titan's back as they made room for evacuating the other stranded motorists, but he'd been sure to keep the team apprised of its location.

"Turned him over to the Heroes who were collecting gang members a few hours ago." Titan didn't mention that he'd been sure to tell said Heroes about how much Eli had helped, even after the primary evacuation was done,

and that he was *not* to be treated with hostility. Thankfully, the Hero Titan talked to had been on the job long enough to understand a good asset when she saw one. If it had been a younger Hero, Titan would have had to put a little fear into them to get the point across, and that was just pointlessly exhausting.

“Too bad he rolls with the bad guys. That power of his could come in pretty handy doing our line of work.” Hexcellent popped open the door of the SUV and sank into a seat, resting for the first time in hours.

“He’ll catch a decent break for all the help he gave us. Who knows, after that he may make himself into a useful member of society.”

“I don’t know who you’re talking about, but I can guess it’s not me.” Zone came trudging forward from a small alley, his whole body coated in the white chalky dust caused by collapsing concrete.

“Nah, someone with an actual future instead of a downhill slide of crappy endorsement deals and hosting local cable television shows,” Hexcellent replied, her voice oddly cheery in spite of the words she chose.

“At least I won’t be fifty and still trying to sell that goth sex-symbol vibe,” Zone countered.

“Good enough for Elvira, good enough for me,” Hexcellent shot back.

“So glad to know that if I ever lose track of my team, I can just follow the sounds of verbal abuse,” Galvanize said as he and Bubble Bubble approached. “I’d tell you to keep it indoors, but honestly I doubt anyone is paying us much attention by this point. Most of the press has packed up and gone now that the thrilling part is over.”

“If they’re going to take what they want and run off that quickly they could at least leave us cab fare on the dresser.”

Everyone turned to Bubble Bubble whose pale, freckled skin immediately began to blush as she realized that she’d spoken aloud what had clearly been intended as internal dialogue. “Sorry, I’m just. . . I’ve been making energy spheres for hours. I’m pretty wiped upstairs.”

“Don’t you dare apologize, that might be the best thing to come out of your mouth since you joined this team,” Hexcellent said. “Though, yeah, I think we’re all drained enough to have goofy-brain.”

“I actually still feel pretty wired, despite my body screaming for

sleep,” Zone said.

“Happens to most people after a really big job,” Titan told them. “Even though you’re tapped out, your brain is still on high alert. My teams and I used to go to a bar afterward. A little beer and relaxation helps shift your gears down, letting you actually get the rest you need. But I’m sure you lot have some sort of meditation yoga vegetable enema way to decompress after one of these.”

“I know that was meant to be a joke, but it’s so close to the truth that now I’m depressed.” Hexcellent swiveled to Galvanize, whipping out her best innocent expression, which was pretty awful. “Can we do the bar thing instead? Pleeeeeeeeeeeease?”

“Absolutely not,” Galvanize replied. “You know how Mr. Greene would react if pictures of us drinking surfaced—let alone in costume and in public—don’t you?”

“What if you did it at one of Mordent Holding’s restaurants?” Titan asked. “They own a bunch of bar and restaurant chains. After a big, publicly visible thing like this, if we went and downed a few at one of their places, it might make for good advertisement. Get it on the news, bill the place as a watering hole for local do-gooders, all that stuff.”

“That is an oddly business savvy suggestion, coming from you,” Bubble Bubble noted.

“Former small business owner.” Titan thumped his chest with unabashed pride.

“I will consent to calling the idea in while we head back,” Galvanize said. “If Mr. Greene gives the okay, and we all want to go, then I’d be all right with it.”

“Oh, we all want to go,” Zone said. “I haven’t been allowed to drink anything with that many carbs and calories in so long that my mouth is literally watering at the thought.”

“I would like to second the sentiment, though very pointedly not echo Zone’s exact word choice,” Bubble Bubble said.

“Then it will be up to Mr. Greene,” Galvanize replied. “Everyone pile in, and be quiet while I make the call. This is already a long shot, so let’s make as good of a pitch as we possibly can.”



## 61.

To Galvanize's great surprise, Mr. Greene actually agreed with Titan's suggestion to let the team be seen dining in one of Mordent's chain restaurants. While the two men might not see eye to eye on many a thing, Mr. Greene was not the type to let a personal distaste for someone skew his ability to spot a money-making idea. After a brief back and forth, it was decided that the team would stop off at Mealttime Jamboree, a family-friendly restaurant with appallingly bright colors and various knick-knacks on the walls. They were to sit in the bar section, though not at the bar, and were allowed two alcoholic beverages per person.

Despite the strict rules placed on their outing, the mood in the SUV couldn't have been more boisterous as the team pulled up in front of the garish yellow and red sign. They piled out quickly, partly in excitement and partly because five bodies that had been deprived the chance to shower and then worked for several hours did not make for a pleasant environment when crammed together. Galvanize led the charge into the restaurant, speaking briefly with the hostess, who led them directly to an already-prepared table in the bar area. Mr. Greene had clearly called ahead to give the staff a heads up, as evidence by the fact that was an extra-large stool to accommodate Titan as they sat down at the chest-high table. He'd also given the press a tip, at least gauging by the number of patrons sitting about with actual cameras, all of them keeping their distance yet watching the costumed team with laser focus.

"Feels weird to be just. . . out here," Hexcellent muttered as they settled into their seats.

"You do appearances all the time," Titan said.

"Sure, but then I'm in my element. Those people know who I am; some of them even came to see me. Being in full gear, just sitting around in public view. . . I don't know, it feels different."

"I'll second that," Galvanize chimed in. "But I don't think it's different in a bad way. I'm rather enjoying getting to let this side of me out on the town instead of vanishing once the work is done. Now then: we each only get two drinks, all of which is going on the company tab so that Mr. Greene can verify that, so I suggest you choose them wisely."

By the time the bartender, who was doubling as a waitress, came by,

the team had perused the menu extensively to make sure they got the best options available. Most went with their favorite drinks, the ones they'd been banned from for so many years now, but Hexcellent decided to take Titan's recommendation on a local craft beer, which he also ordered. Their waitress, a pleasantly bubbly woman named Muriel, wrote everything down and quickly scampered away. Despite the fact that only one of the people at the table was a certified Hero, Muriel was clearly cape-struck by serving so many people in costume.

"Check it out." Zone pointed to one of the multitude of televisions suspended around the restaurant, this one playing scenes from the rescue effort they had just been part of. Amidst the wreckage and turmoil, there were clear shots of people being hauled to safety, sometimes even by one of their team. Titan got the most screen time, which surprised no one, but Bubble Bubble, Galvanize, and Zone were also featured relatively frequently. Hexcellent made the fewest appearances, which seemed unusual to Titan until he remembered that she'd been paired with a large demon that had blades for arms. Family-friendly imagery, it was not.

By the time they finally looked away from the television, their drinks had arrived and Muriel had made herself scarce once more. Everyone reached for their respective glasses and started to drink, but Titan held up a hand to stop them.

"If you don't mind, I'd like to do a toast. I realize this probably isn't the best place for it, but hell if I know whether another chance for us to all have drinks in our hands is going to come around." Titan cleared his throat softly then raised the frosted mug holding his beer.

"You all did great work today, just like you do every time we step out there. I don't think it's a secret to anyone that I was reluctant to sign on with a group of PEERS when I first came back, and that was due to nothing more than my own stupidity. You four are as brave, determined, and good-hearted as any Hero I've stood beside, and I am damned proud to be a part of this team. Cheers."

Everyone took a small sip of their drink, nodding appreciatively at both the sentiment and the wonderful flavor touching their tongues. Silence descended on the table, no one quite sure what to say to follow Titan's kind words, until Bubble Bubble finally spoke.

"For what it's worth, you've certainly turned out to be far less a burden than we were expecting."

“Glad to hear it,” Titan replied. He was slowly beginning to get a feel for the most stoic member of their group, and he had a hunch that she was fonder of him, and the others, than she might like to let on.

“We could have done worse,” Zone agreed. From him it was as good of an olive branch as Titan was likely to receive, and he nodded his head in appreciation.

Hexcellent sighed and rolled her eyes. “I guess if we’re all going to have this emotion-fest then I’ll say that yes, it’s not terrible having you on the team. You damned sure have a knack for making things more interesting, I’ll give you that. I can’t say I remember a single time Mirror Fog whipped the shit out of Elemental Fury on pay-per-view.”

“Oh right, that happened before you joined the team,” Galvanize said, taking a small sip of his dark beer.

Everyone at the table, save for Titan who had never met the former Hero Liaison, stared at Galvanize in wide-eyed confusion. It wasn’t at the suggestion that Mirror Fog had pulled the same stunt as Titan; that was patently ridiculous. No, their shock stemmed from one simple fact about what they had just heard: Galvanize had made a joke while in costume.

“What?” Galvanize said as their stares began to make him fidget in his seat. “You guys are the only ones who can kid around?”

“Not the only ones who can, just usually the only ones that do,” Zone pointed out.

“Though I loathe to admit it, it seemed Hexcellent was righter than she knew,” Bubble Bubble said. “Titan’s presence truly does keep things more interesting.”



## 62.

As much as Owen would have liked to lie down in his bed once the team got back to the penthouse, such luxuries would have to wait. Instead of passing out and finishing his sleep that had been so suddenly interrupted, he stripped off the costume that was coated in chalky concrete dust and grime, laid out a fresh one, and hit the showers. It took a long while and a lot of strong-handed scrubbing to get all the dirt off of him, but when eventually he emerged he at last felt clean.

Silly as it seemed, Owen had learned over the years that whenever he had to go into a place as an authority figure, he felt it put him in the mood to make himself presentable. Owen had never much been one for leadership roles during his Hero days. There were always smarter people than him on the team, ones who could look at a situation and immediately see where best to deploy every asset they had. Those were the people that took up a leadership role, and Owen was more than happy to give it to them. He might be one of the most lauded strongmen in the world, but he was still just a strongman at the end of the day. Melee was his bread and butter, where he shined and where he felt most at home. Given a choice between having his boots on the ground, staring down a hundred enemies or having to make the calls that would determine who lived or died during a fray, Owen would have taken the hundred enemies any time.

Still, as his star had risen all those years prior, it had brought with it a certain amount of prestige. Titan had become a role model, an icon, one that many people, including other Heroes, looked up to. With that had come public speaking gigs, being chosen to chair meetings, and even getting called upon by other Hero teams to work with their own strongmen. Owen didn't relish such roles, but he accepted them at the time as the price of fame.

Over a decade later, Owen Daniels was no longer certain if such a price was worth it. Time off had given him the perspective that perhaps fame itself was the price of fame. If he'd been asked by nearly anyone in the world to make an appearance as Titan for anything other than helping his team, saving people, or punching bad guys, then Owen would have likely told them to go fuck themselves. Topsy was different, though. He was an old friend, one who'd been with Owen back when they were doing all they could to survive in the insane world where Heroes fresh off their internships roamed. Even

beyond that, Topsy had been one of the people who stuck with him during the Titan Scandal. Owen had spent two weeks on the man's couch as the media hunted him and he tried to think of what he could possibly tell his wife and sons to mend the relationships. More than one person he'd counted as a friend turned their back on Owen Daniels during those weeks, but never Topsy. Which meant if he was the one who needed help, then Owen was damned sure going to deliver.

Before leaving the peace of the penthouse and heading out on the town, Owen paused to put in a quick call to order more costumes. He'd thought that doing a job with less direct battle would mean he wouldn't go through so many of the things, but it seemed the strongman's clothing curse was still at work. His supply was dwindling dangerously. At least his supplier cut him a break on bulk orders, a formality they extended to most of the Heroes that got down in the rough and tumble with real frequency.

That done, Titan took the elevator down and stepped out into the last rays of the setting sun. He could have taken the town car or just used his own vehicle since it was stored in the garage, but tonight he felt like walking. A lot of Heroes didn't care to do street patrol; they felt like it lowered the sense of terror a criminal felt at the sight of them. But Owen had always thought it added a sense of danger to the punks' daily lives. Seeing a Hero exploding out of the sky or bursting from a portal was one thing, but to just be walking along and suddenly find one's self in the presence of such power was jarring, and served to remind them that Heroes could appear at any time. Owen liked the idea that he was making sure everyone out there was always on their best behavior.

His jog was a long one, but nearly-endless stamina and powerful leg muscles meant he could close the distance with haste if it was called for. Since he'd left early enough, Titan took his time running through Brewster, nodding and waving at civilians as he passed them. The Wild Bucks' base was in what had once been an industrial area, before the primary company's illegal environmental practices were brought to light and they were fined out of existence. Despite the area being certified by the city as safe, not many people wanted to live on land associated with terms like "contaminated" and "biological hazard." Bad as it was for property values, it was perfect for Hero teams that needed an isolated area to set up shop that was still in decent proximity to the city they watched over. Legacy teams like Elemental Fury might have had fancy mid-lake accommodations, but most Heroes were just trying to find a spot that could be rebuilt cheaply after it was attacked.

As Titan jogged past thick iron gates that were half-rusted and half knocked down, he spotted a familiar figure standing in the middle of what had once been a private road. Topsy smiled at the sight of his old friend, and the two men shared a brief hug after Titan closed the distance between them.

“Really appreciate you coming out,” Topsy said as the hug ended. He looked tired, even more so than the last time Titan had seen him. No doubt the DVA was putting his people through the wringer, and him along with them. Titan didn’t exactly disagree with the need for that, though he wished they’d taken more care to leave his friend out of it.

“Don’t worry about it. I owe you a lot more than this.” Titan did a quick scan of the area, noting that there was a large building with better upkeep than most of the others to his right: either their actual base or the entrance to it, by his estimates. “How bad are things?”

“They’re pretty shitty,” Topsy admitted. “The DVA finally made its call last week, and I lost two of them. One has been busted back down to intern and had heavy restrictions put on how he can use his power, while the other is all the way out.”

Titan nodded, but otherwise kept his face stoic. Being a Hero was a privilege that came with a lot of responsibility. If one couldn’t live up to that responsibility, they didn’t have any place being a Hero and damned sure wouldn’t be once the DVA got a hold of them. For the amount of destruction he’d seen, only one person being tossed out on their ass was actually pretty restrained on the DVA’s part.

“That means you’re down to a three-person team then?”

“For the moment,” Topsy replied. “I honestly think if the whole team wasn’t pariahs right now they’d have split off and joined up with other Heroes. Problem is, after all that mess they caused, no one would want them and they know it. Rock and a hard place.”

“Well, I can’t change their situation, but hopefully I can help them find the best way to handle it,” Titan said. It was the sort of thing he was supposed to tell his friend, even if they both knew it was largely bullshit. “Take me in so I can meet the tykes.”

## 63.

Owen was surprised at how nostalgic he felt as he tooled around the nearly-abandoned building. The beaten exterior concealed a fair amount of furniture and creature comforts within, but it was still an overall sparse space. In fact, most of the interior had been left bare, save for a few weights in the corner. From the dents and broken pieces of concrete in one section of the building, Owen immediately recognized the sparring area. All in all, the Wild Bucks' base felt a lot like the one he and Topsy had shared once upon a time: the base of a new Hero team just starting up, trying to do their best on a barebones budget.

Several mismatched chairs had been pulled together in this central space, only a few feet away from where a large throw rug marked the entrance to what appeared to be the living room where three costumed Heroes were waiting for him. They hopped to their feet as soon as Owen stepped into view. Two were men, one wearing the familiar black fabric of someone whose shape would be drastically changing, while the other sported a simple black and blue costume with some interesting swirled patterns. The last member was female, and her costume was red and silver with curiously empty spots on her shoulder and outer thighs. They all stared at Owen, at Titan, with silent admiration as he and Topsy walked through the empty space to their chairs.

Enjoyable as Owen found nostalgia, it didn't blind him from the fact that Topsy had clearly left something out when he talked about training these kids. His old friend had said he was hired on to coach them, but Owen doubted this team could afford take-out more than once a week, let alone the training of a Hero from someone as experienced as Topsy. More than likely, that meant a family relation of some kind. It at least explained why Topsy was sticking around even after the colossal fuck-up. Most Heroes who'd lived that many years understood a lost cause on sight.

"Let's start with introductions," Titan said at last. "You'll forgive the presumptiveness, but given the events of the last month or so, I'm going to assume you all have a pretty good idea of who I am. Since everyone in the room is familiar with Topsy, we'll go ahead and skip him too. Tell me your names and what you can do." It was a faux pas to ask any Hero how their power worked, since the exact mechanics could often betray a weakness in it, but asking what they could do was usually general enough to get a sense of

one's capabilities.

"I'll start," said the young man in the blue and black costume. "My name is Deadlift, and I am, or was, the leader of this team." His voice was crisp and strong, but there was enough doubt hidden in his blue eyes to betray the uncertainty that had to be weighing on him after all that had happened. "My power is that I can lift and wield pretty much anything."

"Super strength?" Titan asked.

"If I may, sir, it's easier to show than tell," Deadlift said.

Titan nodded, and Deadlift closed the gap between them. The young Hero reached over and grabbed Titan's meaty triceps with a firm grip. To Titan's surprise, he felt himself rise from the ground as Deadlift raised his arm, effortlessly lifting the man who weighed hundreds of muscle-heavy pounds in the air as if he had the mass of a cloud. There was no strain on Deadlift's face, no visible effort in his muscles. In that moment, Titan understood: it wasn't that Deadlift had super strength, it was that his power affected the weight of whatever he held.

Deadlift set Titan carefully back down and walked back to rejoin the others. Next to speak was the shifter, a thickly built young man with a freshly shaven head. When he spoke, his voice was friendlier than Titan was expecting, lots of energy and pep, despite their dire circumstances.

"My name is Kaiju, and as you can probably guess from the costume, I'm a shifter. If you've seen video or pictures of us, I'm the fourteen-foot-tall dark red one. I can shift if you need me to, but I'm not the quickest, so it will take a bit for me to get in and out of form."

"That won't be necessary. I've seen your shifted form already," Titan said. He had indeed taken note of the massive, scaly creature shown with the Wild Bucks during the footage he'd found. Shifter had been obvious, but it was still impressive. The bigger a form someone shifted into, the longer the process took. For this kid to have made it through the HCP he must have been impressively quick on the shifting draw.

"That just leaves me," said the woman in the red and silver costume. "My name is Juiced, and there's really no way to tell you anything about my power without giving away the whole kit and caboodle. Let's just say I'm a strong woman." Juiced had the vague remains of an accent that Titan placed as from somewhere in the northeastern United States. Maine, if he was guessing.

She reached down to the floor and picked up a water bottle that had escaped Titan's notice before. Twisting off the cap, she gulped down several swigs of the beverage, and as she did her body changed visibly. Her already well-defined HCP-grad muscles swelled and she grew at least an inch and a half taller. The gaps in her costume suddenly made much more sense, as it became clear that her movement would have been rapidly hindered by constricting fabric in those spots. Juiced lowered the bottle from her lips, and Titan noted that she hadn't even drunk a quarter of what was inside.

"I'm a metabolic converter. When I drink a certain liquid I get stronger, tougher, bigger, and can even heal faster. Diminishing returns kick in, of course, and pretty quickly at that, but I can still get powerful enough to hold my own."

Titan nodded and watched as Juiced set the bottle down. She had pointedly avoided mentioning what was inside of it, and he made certain not to ask. The Hero had already given away much of her secret out of formality; there was no way he would be so rude as to try and uncover the part she clearly kept under strict guard.

"It's a pleasure to meet you," Titan said. "All of you. It's clear that you have some interesting abilities, and from the fact that you're HCP graduates, I'm certain you know how to use them. That said, I'm not here just for fun and socialization. Given what you've been through in the past weeks, I'm sure you're all keenly aware of the situation, but I'm going to say it anyway, because harsh truths need to be met head on if you're going to conquer them." Titan paused for a moment, and made certain to look every Hero there, Topsy included, directly in the eye.

"The Wild Bucks are on the verge of being dissolved, and I'm not sure that anything can stop it from happening."

## 64.

“I’ll be honest, that’s a little less optimistic than we were hoping for,” Deadlift said, filling the silence that had descended after Titan’s declaration. “Don’t get me wrong: we all know we’ve screwed up. But the team members deemed responsible for that were handled by the DVA. We just want to make a fresh start and put that behind us.”

“There is no such place as behind you, no such thing as a fresh start.” As he spoke, Titan felt old, his years weighing down those massive shoulders in a way that not even hundreds of pounds could. “Even if you could purge the record, change your mask, begin with an all new identity, the mistakes you’ve made will still carry on with you. No one else might know they’re there, but you will. And the more that get heaped on, the heavier each one becomes. Your team’s mistake caused hundreds of thousands, if not millions, in property damage, and that’s something the DVA won’t likely ever let you forget. But more importantly, it cost nine people their lives, and that’s something *you* should never let yourselves forget.”

Juiced began to speak hurriedly, words tumbling over themselves to get free of her mouth. “We were cleared-”

“Maybe you didn’t make the big mistakes, but those two who got held accountable were your teammates, people you put your trust in,” Titan said, interrupting her for both of their sakes. Talks like this were hard enough when everyone was receptive. Odds were that if she got the chance to dig into a position, it would make her more stubborn and unlikely to listen, and they had to hear this if they ever wanted to rise above it. “Sometimes innocent people get hurt in what we do. It’s inevitable, because if we don’t step in then a lot more would be affected, but it doesn’t change the responsibility we bear for those actions.”

“I . . . I thought it was eight.” Kaiju was staring at the ground, and Titan could make out the slight glisten of tears through the sides of the eyeholes in his mask. His voice, only moments ago full of life and humor, sounded beaten.

“Eight at the scene,” Titan said, lowering his own voice by several degrees. “A ninth killed himself when he heard what happened to his wife. The DVA didn’t tell you about it because it wasn’t directly linked to your

actions, though I think we all know better than that.”

“Titan. . .” Topsy was staring hard at his friend, clearly struggling between protecting his team and having them hear the truth. He was invested in these kids and obviously didn’t want to see them get broken by one bad call. At the same time, he had to know that what Titan was doing was necessary. Casualties were part of the job for any Hero. If one didn’t find a way to deal with it, they’d be buried under the guilt, and if they never acknowledged it. . . well, that was how the true monsters were made.

“There is no fresh start,” Titan repeated. “Not in that perfect world where no one knew about your mistakes and especially not in this one where your entire team’s reputation has been run through the shitter. The other Heroes don’t trust you; they think you’re all half-cocked liabilities, and not without good reason. That’s not even mentioning the DVA, who are probably only looking for one screw up to pull the rest of your certifications.”

“So. . . that’s it? Topsy brought you all the way over here to tell us that no matter what we do, we’re fucked?” Deadlift asked.

“No. Topsy brought me over to lay down the harsh truth in a way that no one who is close to you ever could. You want to keep going in the Hero world, want to work with people who don’t trust you and a public that hates you? Then you need to go in with your eyes wide open. Don’t waste time thinking about forgiveness or redemption; those are fairy tales we use to make the world more palatable for children. What you’re walking back into is going to be shit. Shit so deep you’ll have to fight to keep from choking on it. There is no light at the end of the tunnel; there is no undoing what’s been done. If you hope for something other than the shit, then the shit becomes unbearable.”

“Then why would we go back in?” Juiced asked. Of the three, only her tone remained unchanged. Titan had a feeling she was more personally vested in what had gone down than the others, at least in her innocence at the scene.

He prepared to tell her why, but Kaiju beat him to the punch.

“Because we can still help people.” Kaiju raised his head, making the guilty tears in his eyes all the more apparent. There was nothing wrong with crying over lives lost. Heaven only knew how many times Titan had broken down in his early years when he heard how many people he’d been too late to protect. Titan didn’t judge Kaiju for crying, but he decided he liked the kid based on the fact that he lifted his head. Of them all, Kaiju seemed to feel the



guilt the strongest, and he wasn't letting it stop him.

"We can still do what we spent so many years training for," he continued. "It doesn't matter if no one trusts or likes us, we can still make a difference. And we should, because even if Titan is right about there being no such thing as redemption, I still want to end my life saving more lives than I cost. Maybe that's selfish or stupid, but right now it's not something that I can say I've done and I hate myself for that."

Another fog of silence fell upon them as Kaiju's words faded, and once again it was Deadlift who ultimately broke it. "If we press on, we do it knowing that things will be awful, and that we'll be a single fuck up away from being out on our asses. But we can press on. Is that what you wanted us to understand?"

"It's a start," Titan replied. "Logistically, you lot need to work like hell on your training to make sure you minimize casualties and damages. Getting rid of your problematic members will likely go a long way toward making that better. Training is important, it's vital, but all the effort in the world wouldn't make a difference if you didn't have a firm grasp on what was waiting for you outside these walls."

"Thank you," Kaiju said, a bit of the former life returning to his voice as he unashamedly wiped his eyes. Titan couldn't be sure, but he suspected that whatever link Topsy had to this team was through Kaiju. The kid had the sort of aura that made people want to help him.

"I have a question," Juiced said. For the first time, she seemed quieter, less certain in her words. "And I don't want you to take this the wrong way. I'm not trying to turn the tables or invalidate what you told us; I just want to understand a bit better."

Titan nodded, and Juiced continued. "Have you ever. . . made a mistake? Maybe not as big as ours was, but. . . you know."

"Three hundred and forty seven people." Titan said. His voice didn't waver or soften, because this wasn't a thought that suddenly sprang to mind at her question. That number was with him every day, in everything he did. There was no change as Titan talked about his number, because the usual Titan was always thinking about it, in some form or another.

"That's how many people I wasn't strong enough, or fast enough, or smart enough, or sometimes even ruthless enough, to save. I have a list with all their names on it. Some of those were from dumb mistakes I made; some I

still look back and can't think of any way that I could have saved them. It doesn't matter why it happened, though. At the end of the day I fell short and people died. That's why you train, that's why you push forward, that's why you always have to be better. So that the next time you go out, just maybe you can come home without having to write another name on that goddamned list."

## 65.

“You came down on them hard.” Topsy pulled a beer from the mini-fridge in his room, then grabbed a second and offered it to Owen.

“No one out there is going to be gentle with them. Better they face what’s ahead with one foot already in their ass so they don’t forget what’s waiting for them.” Owen accepted the beer and sat in one of Topsy’s old chairs. He was pretty sure it was one that been around at the Gentle Hammers’ base so long ago, and now it had made the trip to Topsy’s sparse quarters with the Wild Bucks. “Besides, they’ve got you for the kid gloves.”

“I think I may have used those too much.” Topsy fell into his own chair, a more recent acquisition that almost would have looked at home in the penthouse. “Maybe if I’d been a bit sterner things wouldn’t have gone the way they did.”

“None of that,” Owen said. “All we can do is guide the young ones. Set a good example. Teach them what we learned through our own mistakes. How much they take from it is on them. You’re no more accountable for their fuck-ups than the older Heroes we got advice from were for ours.”

Topsy snorted and shook his head. “The one I remember the most was them telling us we shouldn’t try to form a group out of just physically-gifted Supers. Said we needed a little variety if we wanted to be of any use at all.”

“Well, that was different. They were dipshits.” Owen took a swig of his beer to punctuate the point. He keenly recalled all the older Heroes saying a team needed diverse skill sets to be of any use at all. Even back then, he knew they were wrong. There was something to be said for specialization, and a team full of coordinated heavy-hitters would be useful in all kinds of situations. History had proven him right in the end, though the many teams that tried, and failed, to emulate their strategy also showed that conventional wisdom hadn’t been entirely off base. Specialty teams were doable, they just weren’t easy.

“Maybe so, but part of me wishes I’d given these kids the same advice instead of agreeing to coach them.”

“Topsy, if you hadn’t helped them who knows how much worse things would be? They might all be stripped of their certification, or up on trial for

gross negligence. I'm sure you helped, though I do wish you'd tell me why you were doing it. There's no way this team can afford you."

"That obvious, am I?" Topsy sighed, but it was clear he'd known from the beginning that Owen would figure it out. Unlike many idiotic criminals, Topsy knew better than to judge a man's brains by the size of his muscles. "Deadlift is the nephew of a Hero who interned under me. He was a good man; we even teamed up on several occasions after his internship was over. Poor guy passed about two years back."

"Died in the field?" Owen asked.

"Cancer. Still burns my ass that we've got people who can turn mushed bones whole, but we have to lose good people to disease."

"We've all got limits, Topsy. The healers are no different."

"I don't blame the ones who couldn't fix it. I blame the ones who can but would charge half a nation's economy to do it." Topsy took a long draw from his beer to calm down. "Anyway, Deadlift came to me after his internship was over, said he'd heard how highly his uncle spoke of me and wondered if I'd be willing to coach a team he was planning. Another group of heavy-hitters, like the Gentle Hammers in their prime."

"Makes sense." Perhaps from someone else the words would have been patronizing, but Owen was completely sincere. He knew how deep the bond between Heroes in the field went, doubly so for the ones who shared an internship. His own mentor had been a huge part of his early career, and Owen had visited the man frequently long after his teacher's cape was hung up. "All of that's in the past now. Any ideas about what you'll do with them in the future?"

"The ones who want to keep going, I'll teach," Topsy replied. "If anyone decides to bail out. . . well, this life isn't for everyone. Can't say I'll blame them. Those that remain are going to be drilled six ways to Sunday, though. I'll be damned if I'll have another incident like this on my conscience."

"I can't speak on the ones that are gone, but I think those three have their hearts in the right places. And after what's happened, they have a firm understanding of the consequences of their actions. With enough training and direction, they may just be able to pull themselves out of this hole, one day."

"I truly hope so," Topsy said. "Of course, you know what would help

a lot? If an older, more experienced, still-active Hero joined the team. Someone who knows how to deal with adversity from the media and can watch out for them in the field.”

“Topsy, I’ve already got a team,” Owen said.

“A team of corpies, of which you’re the babysitter. I’ll admit this team might be bottom of the barrel right now, but they’re still Heroes. You could be back out in the field, stopping real criminals. I know you must miss it, that’s why you came back.”

“I came back because I wanted to make the world just a little bit better,” Owen corrected. “And yes, I wanted to make sure I was around for the big threats that might get other Heroes killed. If you’d made me this offer a few months ago, I probably would have jumped at it, but that was before I got to see what it was like working with that team of corpies. You know what I discovered in that time? I *like* working with my team. We’re out there saving lives, helping people, and at the end of the day I have a lot less blood on my hands. I’m still around for when the big problems pop up, but I’d rather spend my days making a difference like this. At least for now.”

Topsy nodded his head, then polished off his beer. “I won’t say I don’t get it, because I do. You don’t even realize how much weight you’re carrying around as a Hero until the day you finally get to set it down. Still, even if you’re around for the big fights, it’s a waste of your potential to have you pulling kittens out of trees.”

“Maybe so,” Owen agreed. “But it’s my potential to waste, and I’m going to stick with my team. Who, speaking of, I need to get back to. Thanks for the beer.”

“Thanks for giving them the talk,” Topsy said, rising to escort his friend out. “And just keep the offer in mind. In case things change.”

“If they do, you’ll be the first to know.”

## 66.

“Thank you for coming by,” Kaiju said, shaking the large man’s hand one last time as they stood at the door to the base.

“We truly appreciated your advice,” Deadlift added.

“It helps to know what we’re facing,” Juiced said.

Owen smiled at the kids and did another round of handshakes. Maybe they’d manage to pull themselves out this, maybe they wouldn’t. All he knew was that it seemed like they were going to do their best, and that alone was something of a triumph.

“Just glad to-”

“Titan, you are being formally activated under emergency protocol Thirty Two C.”

Owen wasn’t sure what was worse, the fact that Dispatch’s voice had spoken in his ear, or the fact that every member of the Wild Bucks had clearly just gotten a similar interruption.

“Titan acknowledges. Wait, a Thirty Two C. . . that means I’ve got hostiles incoming on a base.”

“Correct,” Dispatch confirmed. “The robotic hordes you’ve been interested in have resurfaced. Currently tracking one pack moving toward you, one moving toward Elemental Fury’s location, and one approaching what we’re speculating is Transcendental Justice’s base.”

Owen wracked his brain on the last name, certain he’d heard it before. Finally it clicked: Aether, the woman who’d helped him and Granite with rescue work, was on that team. From the outset it seemed to support Jeremiah’s theory that the bots were using Heroes for refining their abilities. After all, why not go against heavy-hitters? The issue there was that he’d come to the Wild Buck’s home unofficially, so that meant they were the targets, which was odd given their disgraced status. Plus, Transcendental Justice was a middling team in both power and popularity. The only one of the three that made sense to go after was Elemental Fury.

“Do we have any clue as to what they’re after?”

“The Subtlety Heroes have been contacted and are doing what they can; however, at the moment we must assume they seek more destruction and engagement. Assets are being redirected to you as we speak.”

“Wait, how many are heading toward my location?” Owen asked.

“We’ve been able to confirm that each squad is made of nine robots,” Dispatch said.

“I took out four on my own last time, seems like nine is doable. Put the assets toward something more useful. Have them help Transcendental Justice, or keep watch to make sure this isn’t a diversion.”

“There are already assets allocated to those tasks, Titan, and you receiving help is not optional. Every incarnation of these machines is exponentially stronger than before. While you might be fine, you are limited in your capabilities to contain damage.”

“Sorry, sorry. I wasn’t thinking.” Owen was fairly certain he’d heard a slight tremor of annoyance in Dispatch’s usually calm and steady voice. Since she was both a key asset and one of the few constants in his life, he saw no reason to upset her. “Can I get ETAs on the hostiles as well as backup?”

“Certainly. Hostiles will be at your location in less than three minutes. Backup will arrive within seven. The Wild Bucks are being ordered to assist you, but you are to take the lead on engagement until the extent of the robots’ new abilities has been ascertained.”

Even in a group of tanks, Owen was still the one getting shoved to the front lines. He’d have been a bit annoyed by it, except that he would have made the same call, given the choice. After all, he was the least likely to be injured. That was why he’d become a Hero in the first place: to shake off the blows that would cripple or kill others.

“Understood. I’ll have them hang back and focus on keeping the bots contained.” Owen swung his head around to tell the team to get ready, only to find they’d beaten him to it.

Kaiju was no longer recognizable in his shifted form. Fourteen feet of red, scaly lizard towered above everyone. Just glancing at the thickness of his armor and sharpness of the claws made Owen feel sorry for whatever poor tin can the kid got into it with. There was going to be a lot of scrap metal when the day was done.

Next to him, Juiced was setting down a milk jug full of clear liquid, her body already swelling with power as she picked up a second jug. Owen didn't know how much she could put down before diminishing returns kicked in, but he was looking forward to finding out.

Deadlift was the only one not changed physically, unless one counted the giant steel beam he was casually holding over his head. From the looks of it they'd salvaged the thing out of one of the abandoned warehouses. If his power let him swing that thing at full force even though it was weightless in his hands, it could turn out to be an interesting battle.

Owen glanced down and saw the ground at Topsy's feet had cracked, one of the telltale signs that his old friend was warming up. He walked over and calmly put a hand on Topsy's shoulder. "If you can avoid going in, do. Obviously keep them safe as needed, but don't jump in unless there's cause for it."

"Afraid I can't hack it anymore just because my body doesn't ignore aging?"

"My body doesn't ignore aging. It just sort of. . . tunes it out a lot of the time. Anyway, no, that's not why I want you to stay on the sidelines." Owen lowered his voice a few degrees and hoped none of the Wild Bucks had enhanced hearing. "I just came through here and told them how screwed they were, after the DVA no doubt spent weeks grilling them about their mistakes. Right now, there's no way they see themselves as anything more than fuck-ups. What they need at this moment, more than any nice speech or spark of hope, is to put one in the win column. They need to remember what it is they're good at, and in a team like theirs that's only one thing: kicking ass."

"I notice you still plan to go ahead and enter the fray," Topsy pointed out.

"That's different. For one thing, I'm not their coach, so it feels less like a parent keeping them safe. Plus, Dispatch tasked me with handling this. I'm still active, after all." Owen patted his friend on the shoulder reassuringly.

"And last, but far from least, I'm fucking Titan. That means if there's a fight, I'm in the middle of it."



## 67.

When the robots burst into view, Titan could feel the Wild Bucks tense behind him. It was no wonder: they'd been knocked on their asses by the last iteration of these things and that was with two more members on the team. Of course, last time Topsy clearly hadn't been there; Titan knew that just from the fact that any robots had managed to walk away. And he hadn't been there either, which meant that this was going to be a very different fight than the last time.

A pale, salmon-colored beam of light tore out of one of the robots, lancing across the concrete on its way to the Heroes standing forty feet away. As the beam struck the ground it left cracks and scorch marks, causing enough damage to make for rough driving terrain but not so much that a tire would get stuck. Titan calmly angled himself in front of the team and took the beam across his chest before it petered away to nothing. In truth, he doubted something that weak could have hurt anyone besides Deadlift, but it didn't hurt to start things off with a nice show of force. Titan found it interesting that the robots had upgraded their ranged attacks. Part of him wondered if that was in the hopes of taking out Supers like him before they could get in close.

"I'm heading in," Titan announced. "Kaiju, circle around to the northeast; that's the easiest exit they've got so I want you to make sure they don't use it. Deadlift, as I recall you can throw those big objects, so give me some ranged support. Juiced, from what I've seen on tapes you're pretty mobile; run along the outsides of the crowd and pick off the distracted ones. Topsy. . . well, you'll know what to do if it's needed."

Titan burst forward without even waiting for a single member of the team to confirm their orders. Part of this was so he could surprise the robots and hit them before they were ready, but he also wanted to show the team that he trusted them. He'd told them what to do and left them to do it, just as though they were competent Heroes instead of recent screw-ups. Only they could prove which of those definitions truly suited them.

As he drew close the robots tried to spread out, clearly expecting his charge after their last battle. Titan let them. There was no way he could keep all of them wrangled in a single spot without support from a Hero using some sort of crowd control powers. He instead focused on the two nearest to him, grabbing each robot with one of his hands and lifting them into the air. Titan

could hear the crackle of charging weapons and see the robots shuffling to encircle him. No doubt about it: this was a tactic they'd developed for dealing with strongmen. Trying to overwhelm his resistance to damage by attack simultaneously on all fronts was actually a pretty good plan, in theory. Hell, it probably would have even worked. . . against someone else.

It was impossible to see through the series of multicolored flashes that struck him from all sides, so Titan didn't bother trying. He focused on the two robots in his hands, smashing them against the ground and each other over and over until there was nothing but metallic shards to be collected. If the last generation had been able to self-repair, he had to assume these could too, so he wanted to make good and certain these things stayed down.

The group attack died out at last. Titan blinked away the spots in his eyes as he swept the battlefield for fresh targets. One of the robots that had spread out was pinned between two massive pieces of concrete. Another was trying to pull itself up as Juiced hammered it over and over again with her fists; each blow shattered the concrete under its head. Kaiju still stood ready but untested, as none of the robots had made any attempt to flee. Fifty feet away, Topsy was watching patiently as Deadlift hefted up another slab of concrete and took aim.

Four out of nine in the first scuffle and no casualties save for another of Titan's costumes. He quickly made note of all the burns and tears in the fabric and shook his head. If that order didn't come in soon he was going to be fighting crime in sweats and a T-shirt.

Titan leapt forward to grab two more of the robots, hoping they would circle up around him once more. He'd already suspected he could take what they could dish out, but now that he knew for certain keeping them trained on attacking him was the best case scenario. Unfortunately, it seemed the robots had also realized the futility of trying to gang up on him, as they scattered the moment he moved. The three he wasn't reaching for simply bolted, but the closest robot threw itself forward, directly into Titan's path. It was such a strange action that it took him a moment to realize what it had done.

The robot had sacrificed itself, and in doing so it had allowed the other bots Titan was reaching for to elude his grasp. He blinked in surprise as he tightened his grip against his struggling metallic opponent. Titan had dealt with many a mechanical creation in his Hero days, and he couldn't think of any that were programmed well enough to respond to a threat with a sudden act of self-sacrifice. All of their tactics were rooted around attack and defense

coordination. Either this one had been programmed by someone with the brains to set up default responses to an incredible number of scenarios, or it had been given enough agency to make complex calls on the fly. Whichever one it was didn't actually matter: they both spoke to a creator that was *much* smarter than Titan had been expecting.

He quickly scanned the field, taking stock of what the other robots were doing. One had charged Kaiju, another had been snared by Juiced, and two were running toward Deadlift and Topsy. Titan began dismantling the robot in his arms quickly, but not as quickly as he could have if the need were dire. He was the one who had told Topsy these kids needed to score a solid win.

Time to see if they'd be able to pull it off.

Titan was a bit surprised to see Juiced in action. From her swelling of muscles and size, plus the small amount of fight footage he'd witnessed, Titan assumed she would be a straightforward damage dealer like himself, punching and smashing through opponents with enough power to render their defenses futile. As it turned out, though, Juiced had more finesse than that. She was a grappler, bringing her robot to the ground as soon as she had it in her grasp. The robot scrambled wildly, trying to free itself or turn a weapon on her, but Juiced was in complete control from the moment they hit the ground. Locks that were generally used against human opponents to force submission were employed quickly and efficiently to break the robot's limbs and limit its mobility. Juiced wasn't as fast at dispatching her opponent as a true heavy-hitter, but she was more precise than almost any strongman Titan had even seen work. She probably wouldn't fare well in a giant brawl, but one-on-one, the woman was a force to be reckoned with.

Kaiju fell more in line with what Titan had seen on the tapes and expected. His robot managed to fire off one of the beam attacks while closing in the massive reptilian beast, a blast of energy that struck Kaiju right on his scaled flank. The one part Titan hadn't been expecting, however, was that Kaiju's red scales didn't simply hold up under the attack: they reflected the beam upward into the sky. Clearly the robot hadn't been expecting that either; it stopped in mid-motion while still firing the beam from its wrist canon. Most likely it was trying to calculate whether to risk another ranged attack or to try and deal with its opponent in melee. Kaiju didn't give it the chance to make that call, however. He barreled forward on all fours and skewered the robot with one set of sizable, sharp claws. They slid through the robot's tough exterior shell like knives cutting into a very silver cake.

As someone who was in the process of manually ripping apart one of those robots, Titan had a good appreciation for how tough they were. These things had been built to take a beating, and they lived up to it. But Kaiju shredded his opponent like a fourteen-foot-tall food processor bent on destruction. Titan glanced down and saw that Juiced was finishing up with her robot and spreading the pieces she was snapping off in all directions.

Deadlift was the last one to deal with his opponent since he'd been doing ranged work. Unlike the others, he didn't merely stand in place when

one of the robots fired at him. Instead, he quickly rolled to the side, snatched up a concrete column, and hurled it at the reorienting robot like it was made of foam. The robot dodged easily, through the resounding boom that resounded when the column landed was enough to startle anyone, man or machine. Deadlift wasn't bothered, though; he sprinted forward, grabbed the robot quickly by the shoulder, then threw his opponent up into the air.

Titan watched the metallic dot soar through the sky until it broke through the lowest layer of clouds, at which point he lost track of it. Deadlift might not be technically strong, but whatever he did was still damned impressive in its own way. When he glanced down, Titan couldn't help but let himself smile. The last robot, having seen its counterparts be destroyed one by one, had decided to try and attack the only untested opponent still on the battlefield. It was making a rush for Topsy, who stood calmly as it raised an arm to fire one of the beam weapons at him.

The beam of light crackled through the air, racing toward Topsy with incredible speed. When it was only inches away from the older man's body, his defense kicked in. What appeared to be a black tornado encircled Topsy's form, casting wind in all directions and tearing up the ground under his feet. The beam was shredded the moment it touched the swirling mass, whittled away to nothing under the relentless assault.

While most of the Gentle Hammers had been strongmen, there had been a few whose abilities fell outside those bounds. Topsy, with his power to creating swirling energy vortexes, was one such example. The man might not be able to lift a car or shrug off a bullet, but when it came to taking and dealing damage, there were precious few who could outpace him. Sadly, it was also why he'd never risen as high as he deserved in the public's eye. When one had a power of pure, unrestrained destruction, it made people uneasy. Too often they would look at him and anticipate what he might do if he went evil rather than appreciate his efforts as a Hero.

As the beam died out, Topsy let the defensive tornado fall away. The robot raced forward, determined to handle this old man in melee since range was ineffective. As it extended a fist toward Topsy's stomach, he reached out and carefully placed a hand on its metallic forearm. The robot seemed to swell for a moment, like a silver balloon being overinflated. Then it exploded outward, pieces flung all over as the vortex Topsy had placed inside of it came roaring out. The only part of it that remained even remotely unscathed was the fist and forearm Topsy was still clutching in his hand.

Titan was impressed: not by Topsy, who he'd always known was a force to be reckoned with, but by the strength of the Wild Bucks in combat. Even with him and Topsy pitching in, they'd handled themselves smartly and with skill. It didn't make sense that this team had been completely crushed by the last generation of robots. This group was tougher than the last ones Titan had fought and seemed a bit smarter too, so they certainly hadn't downgraded. Something else had changed, clearly, but whether it was removing the other members or the remaining three getting a sense of what the stakes really were, Titan didn't couldn't be sure. He just knew that they had real potential.

As he finished crumpling up his robot, the one Deadlift had hurled into the air became visible once more as it careened toward the ground at an incredible rate. Deadlift was already there, column hefted over his shoulder, and when the metallic man came in range, Deadlift took a steady swing. The robot wasn't quite as demolished as Topsy's had been, but there was no way it would be putting itself back together. Not without a lot of time and buckets of super glue.

"Dispatch, our hostiles have been resolved. No injuries, no need for healing, but we could do with a little cleanup." Titan walked over to the robot still pinned under the concrete slabs. It was struggling, but seemed to be losing power. "Even got one in somewhat decent shape, so tell the tech people to sharpen their scalpels. Or. . . I guess wrenches in this case."

## 69.

Titan and Deadlift rode the elevator, accompanied by a generic rock ballad that seemed familiar yet impossible to place. Walking into a hotel in full costume had been strange enough, but odder still was how the staff had seemed unsurprised to see two Heroes casually saunter in and request to use the penthouse elevator. When Dispatch had given them the meeting location, Titan had almost, *almost* asked her if she was sure it was correct before coming to his senses. If she said this was where everyone was gathering, then it was the spot. Trusting Dispatch was as ingrained in a Hero's life as trusting themselves.

An elegant chime filled the air as the elevator's doors opened, showing not a hallway like Titan had been expecting but rather the foyer of a luxurious suite. Already standing there, tapping his foot impatiently, was Jeremiah, whose handsome face broke into a grin as he saw his guests arrive.

"Titan, good to see you as always; Deadlift, a pleasure to meet you. If you could both come this way, the others are already here." Without waiting for their reply, Jeremiah turned on a heel and walked briskly down one of the halls jutting off the foyer. Titan and Deadlift quickly followed suit, the younger Hero struggling not to marvel at the opulence around him.

Titan had been surprised when Dispatch reported that the other robot squads had been effectively handled, and he'd bordered on shocked when she told him a post-battle meeting was being held less than half an hour after the attack. Obviously, someone had been ready for this, or at least expecting it. Technically only Deadlift was required to attend since he was the leader of the attacked team, but Titan had been invited along for a multitude of reasons, most important of which was his vocal curiosity about why this attack seemed to deviate from the established pattern.

Jeremiah opened the door to a large room with a projector and a finely-crafted conference table. Already seated were Gale and Aether, the representatives of the other two attacked teams. Both looked more or less unaffected by the skirmish, unlike Titan, who was wearing a borrowed sweatshirt that barely fit him.

"My fellow Heroes, I have called you here to discuss the robotic attack you all suffered today," Jeremiah said, gesturing for Titan and Deadlift

to take seats.

“Can we also talk about why you’re in a freaking hotel penthouse instead of a base?” Deadlift asked. “How much does this place cost to rent?”

“No idea, we bought it outright,” Jeremiah replied. “Subtlety Heroes often have to move about, so having multiple locations rather than a static one suits our needs better. Most of my team’s hidey holes are less opulent than this, but they’re also closely-guarded secrets. Consider this place the equivalent of our guest room.”

“Our guest room is a corner where we store our extra weight bench,” Deadlift grumbled.

“Lovely as it is, I’d rather talk about the matter at hand,” Gale interrupted. She and Titan shared a brief look that, while not exactly warm and friendly, at least didn’t dip so cold as to be called frosty. “Namely, why did the robots come after us this time? And why with such paltry numbers? That last wave had no fewer than a hundred units attacking half a dozen different targets, most of them civilian.”

“Quite accurate,” Jeremiah said. “But you left out the fact that this attack also came much earlier than their others. Usually there’s at least a three month gap between attacks, presumably so that more units can be designed and built. Only about a month and a half has elapsed since the last attack, which I believe speaks to why the units we dealt with weren’t nearly as refined. By my estimations, this was not the next generation of robots. I believe they were the same generation of units with some additional features and programming slapped in.”

Aether was hunched forward, fidgeting with the corner of her glove while her forehead creased in thought. “That doesn’t make any sense. Why come after three Hero teams with nothing in common, using already-beaten units and low numbers?”

“That it makes no sense tells us the real reason for the attack,” Jeremiah replied. He produced a remote from his pocket and clicked one of the buttons, causing the projector at the back of the room to hum with life. Moments later an image displayed on the white wall across from the projector, one immediately recognizable to all present as a map of Brewster.

“As soon as I heard that the robots were attacking Wild Bucks, Transcendental Justice, and Elemental Fury, it was obvious that they had nothing to gain from such an assault. I took this to mean that they weren’t out



for gain at all. . . they were just pawns, calculated losses.”

Titan let out a weary, frustrated grunt as understanding kicked in. “Decoys. They were all decoys.”

“No fair getting ahead of me.” Jeremiah glared at Titan for a moment, then sighed and clicked his remote again. “Delpham Technologies and Pharmaceuticals.” Jeremiah paused to point at the building’s location on the map, which was marked by a large red X on the new slide. “At exactly five minutes past three, an alarm was tripped, indicating that a robbery was taking place. Police responded within four minutes and noted robots fleeing the scene. They put in a call for Heroes to deal with them, but no one was close enough to reach the robots before they somehow dropped out of sight. Now, here’s where the ingenious part comes in.”

Jeremiah clicked again and new slide appeared. This one still marked Delpham’s location, but it also had colored dots representing each of the bases attacked by the robots. Before he said a word, it was evident what had happened. Those three bases formed a misshapen triangle around the company—not especially close to it, but probably nearer than any other Hero bases.

“As you can see, your teams would have been the first to respond to the call, were you not under assault. Additionally, having those three squads make such a ruckus let the fourth one slip through town unnoticed, and ensured most of our Heroes were playing defense rather than offense. From stem to stern, this whole play was never about sticking to their pattern. It was about keeping our hands full while they stole prototypes from Delpham, and damn if they didn’t pull it off perfectly.”

“Bastards,” Gale swore, grimly staring at the map before them. “How did we not see this coming?”

“Why would we have? They’ve never done anything remotely like this. If I didn’t know better, I’d guess that they spent all those other attacks training us to look right, just so they could completely catch us off guard when they went left,” Jeremiah said.

“Let’s focus on the matter at hand,” Titan said. “If they went to all that trouble to successfully rob some place in the middle of Brewster, it must have had something they wanted pretty badly.”

“That was my first thought, too,” Jeremiah agreed. “Sadly, the company was not particularly compliant in giving us a list of stolen goods.

Something about copyrights, industrial espionage, technology thieves, blah blah, you get the idea. It will take me time to get a full list of everything that was taken, but before the meeting I was able to. . . let's call it *liberate*. . . the details of one item."

Jeremiah clicked his remote once more, and a detailed schematic for some cylindrical device popped up on screen.

"Yeah, if we're supposed to know what this is. . . we don't," Deadlift said.

"Nor would I expect you to. This device is a highly experimental gravity distortion field generator, based on the work of a long-dead tech-genius who attacked San Francisco. From what my smarter teammates have told me, it seeks to circumvent the size restrictions inherent to building large machines. Giant robots, for example, currently weigh too much to be able to move on two legs unless the higher pieces were made of far less dense materials. So, unless someone is a tech-genius who finds a workaround, robots must either be small and durable or large and vulnerable. With this device, however, the weight could be compensated for by a weakened gravity field, allowing for almost no limitation on the size of a robot's construction."

Jeremiah paused to make sure the others were taking his message; the worried expressions greeting him made abundantly clear they were. Still, he felt it was good to really send the point home, just so they understood the severity of what faced them.

"To put it simply: the next wave of these machines we face may not come through downtown. They might be the size of downtown."

## 70.

Owen was expecting a bit of a circus when he returned to the top floor of the Mordent Holdings building; after all, the city had just seen another attack by robots, albeit a small one. He was not, however, prepared for the utter chaos he walked in on as soon as the front door opened.

Mr. Greene was on the phone, shouting loudly at someone about defamation and lawsuits, while a myriad of people clustered and scuttled around him, all on phones or laptops of their own. From down the hall came an occasional bout of shouting, which quickly died away into what Owen thought might be sobs or angry screams; often the two were hard to distinguish at a distance. The only member of his team in the living room was Hexcellent, who was playing one of her video games in spite of the people who kept darting in front of the television. Given the expression on her face, Owen wouldn't have been shocked if Huggles or Big Henry soon made an appearance to enforce the sanctity of the screen.

"There is no way I fucked up bad enough for all of this," Owen said, standing next to Hexcellent as the crowd parted and ignored him.

"For once, my favorite scapegoat, you are not the cause of today's drama," Hexcellent replied. "That honor goes to Bubble Bubble, who has had the dubious honor of an internet scandal all her own."

"Did she scowl at the wrong person?" Owen asked.

"If only. Seems someone might have made a little whoopee with one of her commercial directors, and a very incriminating tape leaked online. Since he's done movie work and she's actually becoming well-known, the media decided to run with it. Probably doesn't help that, at the time, he was supposedly dating a well-known actress as well." Hexcellent scowled as a dark-haired woman in a pantsuit strolled in front of the television, causing her to miss the jump to her next platform. "Also not helping that she's on a team with you. Let's just say parallels are being drawn."

"You have to be fucking kidding me." Owen heard another bout of shouting, though this time he had a more accurate guess as to what might be the cause. "I assume Zone and Galvanize are comforting her?"

"More like trying to coax her out of her room, which she locked

herself in,” Hexcellent corrected. “I thought it best if I stayed out of the way for now. She and I don’t have the best dynamic anyway, and I wouldn’t want to see someone as bitchy as me during all this.”

“Good intentions,” Owen said. “But unfortunately, the wrong strategy.” With a single motion he scooped Hexcellent off the couch, knocking the controller to the ground and sending her character off to die. It was enough of an event to draw attention from Mr. Greene and the suits, though only the former bothered addressing it.

“What are you doing?”

“Fireman’s carry, I think,” Hexcellent chirped from over his shoulder. “Also, holy shit you are tall. I never really noticed looking up at you.”

“I’m going to help my teammate,” Owen replied. “And we all need to be there. Don’t worry about it; you stay out here and keep doing damage control. If there’s anything I can do to help, let me know.”

Mr. Greene didn’t even bother to conceal the sneer on his lips. “I’ll certainly keep that in mind.”

“Please do, because I mean it.” Owen rested a meaty hand on Mr. Greene’s shoulder, sending ripples of confusion across the leaner man’s face. “You and I might not get along, but if there are some PR hoops I can jump through to make this easier on Bubble Bubble, say the word.”

“I . . . I will actually keep it in mind,” Mr. Greene said, this time with exponentially more sincerity. He still didn’t seem to trust Owen in the media’s eye, but the man was too powerful of a tool to ignore entirely.

“Thanks.” Owen adjusted his grip on Hexcellent and waded his way through the sea of people and into the hallway.

“You know, I would have just come along if you told me to,” Hexcellent said from flopped over his shoulder.

“I know. I just thought you’d have more fun this way.”

“You’re like the big gay older brother I always wanted.”

They quickly arrived at Bubble Bubble’s door, where Zone and Galvanize were pleading their case. Since the door was firmly wedged closed, he could see how well that tactic was going.

“Owen, we’re glad you could make it back,” Galvanize said. “Things

are a bit hectic right now-”

“I brought him up to speed,” Hexcellent said as Owen set her carefully on the ground. “Even told him B.B. had locked herself up.”

“We’ve tried everything to get her out,” Zone told them. “She just keeps yelling at us to go away, so maybe she wants to deal with this in private.”

“Oh, I don’t have any doubt that’s what she thinks she wants,” Owen said. “But as the only one here to have been on the other side of that door, I also know how important it is she have people reminding her that she’s not alone in all of this. Now pay attention: if you ever have kids one day this is a technique you’ll want to use when they inevitably try to lock you out of a room.”

Owen leaned in and tapped lightly, but firmly, on the sealed door. “Bubble Bubble, it’s me, Titan. I’m here with the rest of the team, and just the rest of the team. We’re here to talk things out with you.”

“There’s nothing to talk about!” Bubble Bubble’s voice cracked halfway through the scream, a telltale sign she’d probably cried herself partially hoarse. “I’m packing up and quitting. My career is ruined.”

“If that’s what you decide to do when you calm down, then we’ll help you pack, but first you need to get some perspective and let the initial wave of panic wash away. That’s what we’re going to help you with.”

“I’m not opening the door!”

“Suit yourself; I’m sure maintenance can get a replacement in the next couple of days. You might want to stand back, though. I’d hate for you to get clipped by any debris.” Owen reared back and closed his hand into a sizable fist.

“What are you. . . are you breaking my door down?!?”

“Or you can open it, but we’re not going to let you be alone. I’ve been where you are, kid. I mean, almost exactly where you are. I know firsthand that right now you’re scared and ashamed, and the idea of talking about it literally fills you with stomach-churning dread because it will make it all become real. But you have to talk about it. If not with us, then with someone we can bring here. You can’t sit alone and let it fester, because you’re going to make snap choices. Decisions that will have much bigger impacts than you

expect. You'll do things that, years from now, when you finally do get that clarity, you'll realize you regret even more than the thing that stirred you up in the first place."

For a long moment no sound came from the other side of the door. Owen pulled back his punch a bit further, then a small click came from the door and it opened several inches. Bleary- faced and red-eyed, Bubble Bubble stared back at them from the small opening to her room.

"You can come in, but only for a few minutes."

## 71.

“Let’s start at the beginning,” Owen said. He scanned Bubble Bubble’s room, having never been invited in before, and noted that it was significantly larger than his own. She’d decorated it tastefully, save for the fact that most decorations featured her promoting some brand of product. It reminded Owen of the rooms a new Hero usually had when getting their first taste of fame and public adulation.

“There’s not much to tell.” Bubble Bubble shut the door behind Hexcellent as the tattooed girl scurried past. “It was two years ago when I was just getting real endorsement deals. Corbin Calhoun was charming and handsome, plus a real director to boot. After we wrapped the commercial he asked me out for dinner and one thing led to another. Two days later I was reading a magazine that talked about him and his girlfriend, who he’d failed to mention existed, going on a vacation to Paris. I never took his calls or worked with him again. Of course, whoever leaked the hotel footage of us making out in an elevator and going into a room didn’t add in those details.”

“I’m going to make a wager that he isn’t telling that version of the story,” Owen said.

“Sadly, no,” Galvanize said. He settled into a computer chair Bubble Bubble had left out while the others settled cross-legged on the floor. “According to Mr. Greene, the story is that Bubble Bubble seduced Corbin, leading him astray. There have even been some sources trying to claim that as a Super, she had some unnatural sway over his actions.”

An all-too-familiar vein throbbed in the back of Owen’s neck, but for Bubble Bubble’s sake he kept his face neutral. Despite decades of research and a well-controlled government program, people still liked to trot out the “who knows what a Super can really do” card if it made life easier on them. Heroes were usually spared the indignity, if only because no one wanted to piss off the people stopping the real bad guys from laying waste to a city. Other Supers weren’t quite so lucky.

“From what I heard, Mr. Greene is launching defamation suits against every news outlet that tries to report that angle. Bubble Bubble’s powers have been on record and used in public for years, so there’s no foundation for such claims,” Galvanize added.

“He can sue whoever he wants to, as long I don’t have to show up at the hearings,” Bubble Bubble said. “It doesn’t matter how this shakes out. No matter what, I’m fucked. All my brands are about being upscale, desirable, and classy. Screwing some director makes me look like a desperate slut. I’d be amazed if most of my sponsors haven’t already dropped me.” She lowered her head and leaned against the far wall, small droplets of tears running down her face anew.

“The ones owned by Mordent will probably stick with you,” Zone said. It wasn’t terribly helpful, but at least he was trying.

“It’s just so unfair. I made one mistake when I was younger and now everything I’ve been working so hard, so *damned* hard, to get is going to burn up right in front of me. I’m so careful, I’m so good, I’m. . .” She turned her head and screamed toward the ceiling, “I’m the perfect pristine fucking mascot!” Her shoulder slumped as the anger seemed to leave her as quickly as it came. “All those years posing, holding my tongue, being demure, all of it is going to be forgotten. . . just because of one stupid mistake.”

“You’re wrong,” Owen said, standing and walking over to his teammate’s hunched form. “Not about all the bad shit coming—you’ve got a pretty firm grasp on that—but about the mistake. You never made one. You’re an adult who had consensual sex with another adult. The only mistake anyone made was this Corbin guy for lying about being single. These next few days are going to suck, and the weeks to come will be rough, but don’t you dare think for a minute that you’re to blame.”

“Maybe not, but I’m going to be the one who pays for it,” Bubble Bubble said. “Corbin’s a successful director and a human. I’m nothing but a corpie and a genetic freak. Who do you think people are going to side with?”

“Probably the wrong person, as they often do,” Owen admitted. “But we can’t control them. No Super can make the world think the way they want it to. All we can control is who you think is really responsible here. Some of the blame goes to whoever leaked that video; most belongs to Corbin for making this a scandal-worthy incident. Tell me the truth now, do you really think you did anything wrong?”

Bubble Bubble didn’t answer. Instead, she began to cry again, leaning forward and pressing her already tearstained face against Owen’s borrowed sweatshirt. It was coated in a thin film of concrete dust, but she didn’t pull back. She wrapped her arms around his sizable torso and pulled herself closer. He hugged her back carefully, marveling at how slender and delicate this



woman he'd seen save dozens of people truly was. She was just a damn kid, only a few years older than his sons, and this was what the same media that had torn him down was reducing her to. Anger tried to well up in him, but Owen forced it down. There was no place for rage right now. It might make him feel better but it wouldn't do anything for Bubble Bubble.

"I once crapped myself during a skateboarding competition."

Zone's words broke the melancholy spell that Bubble Bubble's tears had cast, as everyone in the room, Bubble Bubble included, turned to stare at the chiseled, spiky-haired man who was staring at the floor in red-faced shame.

"Whaaaaaaaaat the fuck now?" Hexcellent's eyes were so wide they seemed to have physically grown.

"I had the flu, but I was just starting out and it was my first paid gig. I *really* needed the money. After I did my tricks, and I mean *right after*, my body let me know that the floodgates were opening no matter what, and I could do with that information as I pleased. I managed to duck behind some bushes, but. . . things happened and then there I was, standing around in a competition with my jeans ruined. I was sure my life was over, so I decided to go big. I stripped naked, fastened my helmet over my junk, and streaked past the stands. I lucked out and people thought I was a bad boy instead of realizing what had really happened." Zone finally looked up from the floor to find the entire room staring in rapt attention. "I just. . . my point is that we all have things that are embarrassing. Like, career-wrecking embarrassing. It really blows that the media got yours, so I thought it might help if you knew one of mine."

Bubble Bubble stared at him for a long moment, then snorted out a snotty, half-cough of a laugh. It was a bit disgusting after all the tears, but it was also beautiful to hear. Owen realized it might be the first time he'd ever heard Bubble Bubble laugh, or do anything, without carefully measuring her response.

"I was in a porno," Galvanize said slowly. "Not as an actor—well, I mean, I acted but. . . I was the guy who found the real performers in the ball pit, and no, that is not a play on words."

"Holy shit!" Hexcellent yelped. "Mr. Fly Right was in a skin flick. Please tell me you used a fake name."

"I didn't choose one, but they listed me as Rock Thruster." Galvanize

hung his head in shame while the rest of the laughed and hooted nearly uncontrollably. “It was before I decided to do rescue work, and I had a friend on set. You all get the idea.”

Eyes turned slowly to Hexcellent, who was enjoying her chuckles so much she didn’t notice until the stares had gotten awkward. “Oh! Um. . . shit. You all pretty much know my dark and dirty secrets. Drugs, sex, rock-and-roll, all paired with a nice side of petty crimes.” She looked at Bubble Bubble who, was, in spite of everything around her, smiling just a touch.

“But. . . oh fuck it. Like most Supers I got my powers when I was a kid, so my first summon wasn’t Impers. It was a bunny I named Hopcules, because he was strong and brave, and I called him up because I was afraid of the dark.”

“You are shitting us,” Bubble Bubble said. “You, *you* had a summon that was a fluffy bunny? I have to see this to believe it.”

“Sorry, but I can’t call it up anymore,” Hexcellent said. “Summons are pretty tied up in who summoners are mentally, and I haven’t been that naïve little kid for a long time. I swear on my tattoos and vintage albums, though, it’s the god’s honest truth.”

“As for me, everyone here knows my big secret: destroyed my own marriage because I couldn’t be honest about who I was, even to myself,” Owen said. “I wasn’t like you, Bubble Bubble. I fucked up my own life; you’re just caught in someone else’s blowback. If it’s too much and you have to go, I definitely understand. But if you want to stay and fight to keep that image you worked so hard for, know that everyone in this room has got your back.”

Bubble Bubble looked around to see all of her other teammates nodding and a fresh set of tears came to her eyes. It had been so very, impossibly long since anyone had ever looked out for her. Ten minutes earlier she would have bet all her money that no one cared about her beyond what she offered business-wise. Now that she realized she might be wrong, Bubble Bubble wasn’t quite so keen to give these people up just yet.

“I need a favor.”

“Are we going to just replace ‘hello’ with that now? First you’re trying to set me up on a public speaking gig at Zero’s behest, what can be worse?” Lenny sounded tired, which surprised Owen even with the late hour. Given that the city had seen some actual Hero action during the day, he imagined Lenny would still be up, wheeling and dealing and making sure his clients came out looking great.

“That one wasn’t even for me; I was just passing along the message since you don’t take phone calls from retired Heroes.”

“Now, now, be fair. I take them if they’re from my old clients,” Lenny reminded him. “But I can’t go returning every message I get during the day. I’d spent all my time talking to wanna-be clients instead of working for the ones I’ve got.”

Cold as it seemed, Owen knew Lenny was actually being more honest than arrogant. There were tons of agents in the Hero world, some okay, some awful, and a few tremendous. As a man who fell into the third category, Lenny was in high demand. He could have taken on every Hero that was willing to sign. Others before him had. But it would have dropped the amount of attention he could give each one. Lenny had chosen quality of clientele over quantity throughout the years, and his reputation had flourished for it. Unfortunately, that meant if he actually did grant Owen’s favor then Owen would owe him *huge*.

“It’s actually kind of about that,” Owen said, gathering up his nerve to charge the verbal hill. “I’m assuming you saw what happened to my teammate, Bubble Bubble, on the news today?”

“Sadly, yes. Scouring tabloids and skeevy news sites is one of the many fringe benefits of my illustrious job. Give the gal my condolences, by the way. She’s getting a raw fucking deal and anyone with half a brain in their head knows it.”

“Maybe so, but I want to drill it in to the ones with less than that half.” Owen idly ran his fingers over the battered sweatshirt he’d taken off, getting more concrete residue on his hand. It was now or never; the worst Lenny

could say was no. “That’s the favor I need. I want you to take her on as a client.”

Silence screamed at him through the phone for several long, lingering seconds. When Lenny finally spoke, it wasn’t with annoyance, as Owen was expecting. In fact, even the weariness seemed to have disappeared from his agent’s voice. If anything, he seemed to be barely holding back chuckles of mirth as he responded.

“Sometimes, just sometimes, I honestly forget how big a pair of brass ones you’ve got swinging down there. To be clear: you want me to take on as a client, for the first time ever, a corpie. And not one that’s prime real estate, but one going through a media shitstorm that will likely end up torpedoing her career.”

“She’s probably toast,” Owen agreed. “Unless someone with real skill, a legendary level of talent, were to take her on and steer her to safe shores.”

“Flattery, a nice touch. Little overt, but that’s about what I expect from you.” Owen could hear Lenny sigh. He imagined his agent pacing about, weighing the pros and cons while time was pitted against potential income in that balding head of his. “Listen, Titan, you and me go back a long way, and there’s not much I wouldn’t do for you if needed, but that’s for you. This girl is going to need a hell of a lot of work to keep afloat, and even more if she wants to come out ahead. Truthfully, that might not be a bad thing, though. I’ve been thinking about taking on a few of the corpies with real earning power out there, and pulling her from the fire would be the best exposure I could ask for to show them what I bring to the table. That said, this one isn’t going to be free.”

“Tell me what you want,” Owen said.

“You know damned well what I want,” Lenny shot back. “This year’s Intramurals have two of the supposedly heaviest hitters to come out of the HCP in a decade squaring off against each other. I want what no other agent gets: a seat at the show to judge them for myself.”

“This year it’s being held at Lander, I’ve got almost no clout there. If it were Sizemore, sure, I could swing a few things, but all I’ve got at Lander is kids who won’t talk to me. Why not do the talk for Blaine? He’s more likely to be able to get you in.”

“Already agreed to that, but he’s not sure he can swing it. All he could promise was support. Now, if someone still active in the field, someone who

might still have a few markers to call in were to ring old friends in the Intramural Committee, that could give me the extra push I need to watch this firsthand.”

“I . . . can make some calls. That’s the most I’m able to promise, Lenny. A lot of people voided their chips to me when things went south and you know it. I’ll do everything I can, and I’ll take on some favors if needed, but that doesn’t mean I can make you a promise.” Owen had once been a man who prided himself on never breaking his word. Despite the fact that this character feature had ultimately unraveled along with the rest of his life, he still made it a point not to make a promise unless he truly believed he could keep it.

“Tell you what: you promise me that you’ll do your best and I’ll let it ride for now.” A soft *fwump* of sound filled the receiver, and Owen knew that Lenny had just let himself fall into his favorite easy chair.

“Really?”

“Really. I’m not dumb, I know you can only do so much. Still, you’re a determined guy. If you say you’ll give it your all, then that’s the most I can ask for. Make me that promise, and you can send the girl by tomorrow morning. I doubt she has any other pressing appointments to make. I’m not agreeing to take her on whole hog just yet, but I can at least help get her through the rough patch.”

Owen let out a long sigh of relief. Just knowing Lenny would help made the whole situation less scary and more manageable. He wondered if this was how people felt when they saw a Hero drop in on a scene, like suddenly things might just be okay after all.

“I promise, Lenny. Anything I can do to get you a seat, I’ll do it. Calls start going out tomorrow.”

“Then tell your girl she has a new ally. It’ll be a hard road, but I’ve got a few ideas for how to spin things. Now if I can just make that damn dean push from his side, I might get treated to a real spectacle.”

“These kids supposed to be that strong?” Owen asked.

“Remember Hank Rhodes? One of them is his son.”

Owen indeed remembered Hank Rhodes; while the man hadn’t become a Hero, he was a Super of incredible power and often helped train

Heroes when asked. He'd never met Hank's son, but if his power was close to his father's, he would be hell to defeat.

"Who's the poor bastard going up against him?"

"Graham DeSoto's granddaughter," Lenny replied. "Both, by the way, undefeated in their entire time at the HCP. That's something that, correct me if I'm wrong, not even the great Titan managed to accomplish."

"No need to be mean about it," Owen said. "I came a long way in those four years, and it's not in how you start a race. It's about how you finish."

"Heh, well, you definitely finished strong. That was another Intramural I had to scheme, bribe, and favor my way in to watch. Worth it, though. You made for one hell of a show."

"I like to think I still do."

## 73.

Owen was faced with a problem, one he wasn't quite sure how to deal with. Despite having come up against this dilemma several times before, he still found himself semi-flummoxed each time it reared its head. In fact, it occurred with such regularity that it was amazing he managed to continue being surprised by it.

Sunday had arrived once more, and with it came the team's mandatory day off. Even after several weeks with them, Owen still wasn't comfortable just dicking away an entire day. Sometimes he went active, pitching in as best he could as a Hero, but that was off the table this time. After the previous day's robot battle, he had exactly one lone Titan costume remaining. Delivery for his next batch was scheduled for Monday morning. Until then, he couldn't risk losing his last outfit in case he needed to suit up for a real emergency.

Most of his team was busy, with Bubble Bubble off to see Lenny, Galvanize catching up on paperwork, and Hexcellent having a date day with Spyda. She'd offered to let him join, but a picnic in the park seemed a touch too romantic for him to intrude on. Still, Owen had to give her man points; despite the tattoos and hard rock persona, he seemed to be a real softy. Given how protective Owen was starting to feel about his team, Spyda's dutifulness as a boyfriend was as good for him as it was for Hexcellent.

The only one who didn't seem to have plans was Zone, who had settled into a semi-peaceful silence where Owen was concerned. Old grudges were slow to die, even when one realized the foundation might not be as solid as once believed. Owen understood; the kid was lugging around years of confusion, resentment, and anger that had ended up aimed toward people like Titan. Given the circumstances, Owen was actually very happy they'd managed to get this far. He didn't intend to push it by intruding on the spiky-haired young man's personal time.

Owen briefly considered calling up Jeremiah to see how things were going with the robot hunt, but thought better of it. Pestering him wouldn't make the information come any faster, and at worst, it might give Jeremiah unintentional encouragement. Owen still wasn't quite sure where he fell on his fellow Hero's romantic advances. The man was confident, skilled, and capable; all traits Owen found desirable. However, he was also young, brash, and cocky. Maybe in the Subtlety world things were different, but Owen had

seen too many Heroes with those traits end up in the ground to dismiss the possibility that Jeremiah might get himself killed. All of which ignored the larger issue of if he was ready to actually date again.

In those years at the bar, when he'd just been Owen, things were simpler. He was merely himself, a muscular entrepreneur who was maybe a bit too strong for what even his large frame implied. Now, things were different. If he started dating again, *especially* with another Hero, he'd be doing it as Titan. Maybe that would be a good thing; owning who he was and moving on with his life publicly could be the catalyst that finally took the sting out of the Titan Scandal. Then again, maybe it would undo everything he'd been working hard to fix since he returned. It was a thorny, complicated issue, and Owen was determined to take his time in choosing the proper course. Rash decisions had taken too much from him in the past. Whatever he chose, whether it was for the better or worse, it would be deliberate. He would own his decisions.

Unfortunately, the decision of what to do with his day off still loomed overhead, and that one was proving to be quite a toughie. He could try vegging out in the living room, maybe pick up a few of Hexcellent's games, but he knew himself well enough to guess that doing so would just lead to boredom and the sense of a wasted day. After five more minutes of thought, Owen decided to give it a go anyway, as he was unable to come up with anything else that might prove better.

Stepping into the living room, Owen was surprised to find not just Zone but also two men in lab coats. Edgar and Kirk, or "the docs", were standing watchfully over Zone while he skimmed, signed, and initialed a large stack of thick papers.

"Trying to requisition extra carbs?" Owen almost regretted going with a bad joke to announce himself, but as soon as they heard his voice, Edgar looked up and smiled.

"Ah, Titan! What a treat. We so rarely get to see you about, but I suspect that's to be expected with your indomitable physique. You don't require our check-ups or assistance."

"Or advice, that you can then ignore," Kirk added. That barb wasn't directed at Owen, though. The shorter man's gaze was fixed firmly on Zone, who scratched his name in the stack of documents even faster.

"Ahem, yes, that either," Edgar agreed, shuffling awkwardly.



“Though, if you’d be willing, we’d love to do some basic calibration tests on you. Technically Heroes are exempt from having to fulfill that requirement for the event, but it would still be fascinating to administer.”

“I’m sorry, event?”

“The charity show, remember?” Zone’s sneer was half-assed as his attention was still on the myriad of paper set before him. “Contests, sports, meet-and-greets; Supers from every public occupation coming together to raise money for those in need. We signed up for it last month, and it starts next week.”

“Must have slipped my mind,” Owen muttered. Between Gale and her team, hordes of robots, and Topsy’s students, the charity event had dropped off the backburner of his mind and fallen under the stove.

“Quite all right, it’s not as though you need any additional training to be able to perform well,” Edgar noted.

“And you aren’t likely to blow your damn knees out, either.” Kirk grabbed the stack of papers from Zone as the last signature was put in place, yanking it away angrily. “But I guess that’s no one’s problem but the participant’s.”

“It’s my body; I’ll decide what risks I take. Mordent has its waivers, so leave me alone.” Zone clicked the pen shut and twirled it through the air, tossing it to Edgar before getting up from the coffee table and walking briskly past Owen.

“Kirk, you could have been a bit nicer about everything,” Edgar chastised. “But I do wish he’d have listened to reason.”

Owen didn’t have to ask what they were talking about; he’d seen the way Zone winced for himself. The kid was tearing his body apart with all the sports and rescue work, and unfortunately, he didn’t have one that fixed itself. Owen had half-suspected he was the only one who knew about Zone’s condition, but it seemed the docs had caught on too. Galvanize did once say they were brilliant, after all, mentally-gifted beings who were well-versed in all manners of. . . science.

The realization came crashing down on Owen as the docs were gathering their things and beginning to leave.

“Those calibrations you wanted to do. . . got time for them today?”

Edgar perked up so visibly that Owen feared the wiry man might have tweaked his back. “For you? Certainly we do! Kirk, push everything back. This will be a rare and fascinating opportunity.”

“I’m surprised you’re willing to do this at all,” Kirk said, eyeing Owen suspiciously.

“It’s not totally altruistic. There’s an interesting work problem I’m dealing with, and I’d love to get your perspectives on it.”

“Ah, quid pro quo.” Kirk nodded; clearly this fit better into his world view than simple generosity. “In that case, please follow us downstairs.”

“This feels. . . risky.” Bubble Bubble set down the stack of papers on Lenny’s desk. The outline of their counter-strategy to her scandal was in-depth, smartly-worded, and shockingly comprehensive, especially given that the whole thing had only gone down the night before. She’d known anyone who represented Titan would be good, but even she was taken aback at so much planning done so soon. That said, this was a far bolder strategy than she’d been expecting.

“Risky is an understatement. This is outright courting trouble,” Lenny corrected. “If done improperly, this strategy will torch what little goodwill you have left, pretty much putting you out of business. Whereas if you just try to lie low and weather the storm, you’ll probably end up back to square one, career-wise.”

“I take it there’s some greater gain to be had by this strategy then, if the chance at loss is so much higher.”

Lenny smiled, a surprisingly charming feature on the unkempt, clearly sleep-deprived man. “Smart call. I’ve still got Heroes that I’d have to handhold to that realization.” He reached over and rested a thick finger on the stack of papers resting in front of Bubble Bubble. “Your old image, really your whole character, is dead. No matter what we do, no matter how we frame it, that demure gal who embodied polite, quiet beauty is never coming back. If we sit this through silently, playing it defensive, all we’re doing is clinging to the last vestiges of something that’s already lost. If, on the other hand, we take this route, then we can create a new image out of the ashes from your old one. But, like I said, that only works if you can play it right.”

Bubble Bubble picked up the documents once more, Lenny’s finger sliding off as soon as she touched the papers. “What do you need from me to make this work?”

“There will be lots of sound bites, some PR work, and I’ve got an interview tentatively scheduled for this afternoon to kick things off. But more than anything I need to know if *you* believe you can make that girl come to life. You have to be bold, certain, and unwavering. A lot of people aren’t going to like what you’re selling. This isn’t some milquetoast persona that no one talks about and some people admire. You’re going to piss some folks off,

and if you give so much as an inch, that's all it will take to tear the whole thing down. Only you can say for sure if you're up to the challenge, and really, only you should make the call on something this dangerous."

"It's certainly a change of pace," Bubble Bubble agreed. "But in a lot of ways, I like this one better. If nothing else, she seems a lot more fun. Tell me something though, if you don't mind. Were I one of your actual clients, a Hero, would this be the strategy you recommended for me?"

"Depends on the Hero, but probably not," Lenny admitted, no sense of shame in his voice. "Heroes need to play it safer; they're civil servants sent in to keep people safe. Making a Hero polarizing is dangerous. Some folks will outright refuse to be saved by someone they disagree with. If a Hero were in your shoes, I'd have to recommend something that was a half-step between this and playing it safe."

Lenny leaned forward slightly in his chair, a wicked gleam suddenly twinkling in his eye. "But in that situation, I'd be silently wishing I *could* recommend this tactic to them. Heroes don't have the freedom that you do, Bubble Bubble. I can't make you use it, or even tell you if it's right to do so. All I can say is this is the only strategy I can see that has a chance at putting you ahead of where you were before the fiasco started."

"You do know how to sell a pitch, I have to give you that," Bubble Bubble said. She skimmed the documents one last time before setting them down. "This new version, she seems a bit combative. Do you think people will respond to that?"

"In my experience, it's not the fact that someone's aggressive that turns people off so much as what they're aggressive about. And yeah, you're going to alienate the shit out of a lot of folks. But you're also going to draw in a plenty of people who are just as sick of this bullshit as you."

"If I do it right," Bubble Bubble added.

"Goes without saying," Lenny agreed. "Think you can handle being a little more abrasive and mouthy than before?"

Bubble Bubble chuckled, a soft, practiced sound that couldn't hide a touch of harshness. "I didn't make it this far by not having a bit of asshole in me. Honestly, keeping that suppressed was the hardest part of my job. . . far worse than jumping into fires or risking injury. I understand that this has the potential to utterly lay waste to my career, but since that could happen anyway, I think I'd prefer to go out swinging."

With a quick motion, Lenny produced a new stack of documents from under his desk and slid them over. “That was what I wanted to hear. Welcome aboard, Bubble Bubble; if you sign these then you’re officially one of my clients.”

“Wasn’t I already?”

“Yes and no,” Lenny said. “Titan asked me to help you, so I was going to do that no matter what. But there’s a hefty amount of difference between getting you through one scandal and actually taking you on as a client. To be frank, I dislike working with people that have no guts. Life, at least this life, requires people take chances. If you want the big pay-off, you have to be willing to take the dangerous gambles. You’re not obligated to sign on, of course. I just wanted to let you know the offer was on the table.”

Bubble Bubble stared at the contract for a long moment, then motioned for Lenny to slide the pages over. “Mr. Greene, the man who manages us at Mordent, wanted me to take the safe route. Hole up, let the team do damage control, try and wait for it to pass. That’s the sane move, isn’t it?”

“Unquestionably so,” Lenny agreed.

“Then I’m happy to sign on with you. I too dislike working with the gutless.” Bubble Bubble grabbed a pen and began flipping through the papers, initialing as she read. “Besides, I can’t wait to see the look on Hexcellent’s face when she finds out I’m challenging her for the title of baddest bitch in the house.”

## 75.

“Can you push any harder?” Kirk peered around the side of the metal box where a single protruding bar was being pressed down on by Owen, who was using only his triceps. It was a pretty standard device in the high-end gyms developed for strongmen, built to figure out how much the user could safely lift using any given muscle group. When one measured their workout equipment in the hundreds of pounds, guesses could lead to injury or worse.

“I can, but in my experience this is around where the machine breaks,” Owen warned them.

“According to the reading, you’re only moving the equivalent of one and a half tons,” Edgar said from his position at the console across the room, eyes unmoving from the screen. “These are rated to go to at least three.”

“Yeah, they say that, but given how few Supers out there can even get over one, it’s not a claim that they get called out on often.” Despite his warning, Owen obliged, easily moving the bar lower through the increasing resistance. Plenty of Supers out there could move more weight than he, but they had to do it using telekinesis or anti-gravity or some other trick. Pure physical force usually capped out around a ton per muscle group for most Supers, though obviously they could move far more when not localizing the effort. Even with abilities, the human body was built to have limitations. Strongmen were plentiful, but those who could break the ton-per-muscle barrier were somewhat rarer. The number who were in the same league as Titan could almost be counted on a single hand.

“Stop stop stop!” Edgar leapt up from his seat and waved his arms in the air, as though his impassioned screeches hadn’t gotten the message across.

Owen obliged, forcing himself not to gloat at the slight crackle of snapping metal from inside the metal box as he allowed the bar to raise itself back up. Kirk hurriedly moved a few steps away, while Edgar fell back into his seat and began typing up a storm on his computer.

“I suppose this is the repayment for our hubris. Your strength is well-documented, after all. Tell me, do you have any idea what your actual maximum is these days?”

Returning the bar to its resting position, Owen let go and shook his

head. “I stopped being able to use Hero gyms a long time ago, for obvious reasons, and even with a few ultra-dense weights there aren’t many other gyms that can do much for me. Working out is more of a way to turn off my brain and relax these days. Luckily my strength never goes down, only up, so it’s not like I can get rusty.”

“Fascinating.” Kirk produced a tablet from his lab coat pocket and began typing furiously. After a few moments, he looked up, glanced at Edgar, who was desperately clacking at keys, and realized he was being rude to their guest. “Since it seems the testing equipment will be down for a while, why don’t we use the time to answer the questions you mentioned?”

“It’s not so much a question as me wanting an opinion,” Owen said. “By now I assume you heard about the robots that attacked the other day. . .”

Owen went through the events as he knew them, sharing the information available to him while leaving out the only confidential bit—the stolen piece of experimental equipment—and otherwise bringing them up to speed. He was nearly done when Edgar walked over to listen in, waving off Owen’s attempt to backtrack.

“. . .so honestly, I’m not sure what to ask you here. I just feel like we’re all busting our heads against the walls trying to figure out what’s going on, and maybe some fresh, smart eyes could offer insights.”

Kirk and Edgar shared a look, one that was both easy to read and deeply worrying to Owen. As his story had gone on, they’d seemed less and less surprised by each progressive revelation. The stony resolve with which they faced one another now was a poor fit for the perpetually curious men he’d been dealing with.

“You don’t think-”

“I most certainly do think.”

“But how?”

“Parallel thinking, corporate espionage, simple-”

“Guys.” Owen leaned forward and spoke firmly, cutting off Edgar and causing him to jump slightly. “I’d like to be included in the conversation, if you don’t mind.”

“You explain. I’ll go check it.” Edgar didn’t wait for a reply, he merely rushed out through a glass and metal door into some deeper part of the

lab that Owen had not been privy to viewing.

Kirk cleared his throat and shuffled awkwardly, but after a few seconds of hesitation, he finally pulled himself together and began speaking. “Titan, what you’ve described makes no sense. The way these robots are acting, the strategies in use, sacrificing one unit for another with no time to have received an order. . . It seems like nonsense, if we’re viewing these robots as independent, programmed units.”

Owen didn’t lean forward or shift his weight; he wanted to avoid coming off as intimidating for as long as possible. Still, there was a touch of edge to his voice as he pressed for more information. “I take it you have a theory?”

“A highly unsubstantiated one. Merely a hypothesis based on personal observations from a prior experiment,” Kirk warned. “But, all the patterns that make no sense in individual units do hold structure if each unit is viewed as a piece of a greater whole. All working toward singular goal, prioritizing success over conservation of resources or minimized losses.”

“Like ants from a hill,” Owen surmised. “Their goal is the survival of the queen.”

“Similar, but more like cells in a body,” Kirk corrected. “Each unit has no inherent value; it is only a piece of the true whole. Ants and bees and the like still operate under an individual consciousness, however primitive it may be. To these robots, it’s possible that they have no thoughts of their own, that all share in a single mind. That is to say, it may be that each robot is actually connected to the greater program running them all, thus why they are able to coordinate so perfectly.”

“Wait. . . do you think these things are alive?”

“No no, nothing like that,” Kirk said quickly. “Merely that rather than running a program on each unit’s hard drive, they are all connected to one source that runs remotely and controls the robots like appendages.”

“I’m with you now.” Owen doubted he was really getting all the intricacies of what Kirk was trying to tell him, but he’d at least grabbed the gist. It was an interesting theory, definitely one that put those metal assholes in a new light. Unfortunately, that’s all it was at this point: a theory. “Is there even record of a machine that can do something like this?”

“The creations of Supers with technical abilities are largely classified,



so I can't say for certain how many functional units like what I described have existed, but I do know of at least one prototype that was created by those of the more mundane genius." Kirk paused to look up at the mountain of a man before him then plunged onward. "Edgar and I made it years ago; in fact, it was one of our first projects together. There were serious issues, though, and we shelved it in the Mordent laboratory vaults until time and technology advanced to where we could perfect the design."

"Seems like someone felt the time was ripe." Edgar had reappeared though the doors, a vacant, haunted look on his face. "The prototype is gone, no record of it being checked out. Our work has been stolen."

Whatever else Owen could say about Mordent Holdings, they certainly didn't falter in the face of an unexpected development.

Within five minutes of Kirk calling in the missing invention, dozens of privately-employed security officers swarmed through the lab's doors. Owen was briefly spoken to as they uncovered why he was present in a restricted area. Once it was established that he had been with the docs, who had more clearance than nearly anyone else at Mordent, and that it was impossible for him to have taken anything without being seen, Owen was gently escorted out to the elevator and told to return to the penthouse.

He did so a bit begrudgingly; in truth, he felt like there was a lot more he could learn from Kirk about what this prototype machine had done, but it didn't seem like a good time to press the issue. Even aside from the Mordent security picking apart their lab, neither one of the docs seemed to be taking the news well. Kirk had been flitting about, desperately coming up with new places where the device might have been, only to come up empty-handed. Edgar had been far worse, though. After announcing that the prototype was gone, he simply sat down in one of the rolling chairs near a computer and didn't move. It had taken multiple attempts from security to get any information out of him while Owen was there; Edgar had seemed largely preoccupied with staring blankly at the wall.

Having accidentally set off a panic in his own home, Owen decided to double down and alert the other Heroes to what he'd uncovered. It wasn't much—hell, technically it wasn't really anything at all yet—but it might lead them to something real, eventually. That job was up to Jeremiah and the other Subtlety Heroes, thankfully. Owen's only real focus was on kicking apart whatever defenses were there when they found these bots' home base. Deep down part of him hoped there would be some tough obstacles. It had been a long time since he'd really had to push his limits. A genuine challenge might be nice.

That challenge wouldn't be coming today, though. After sending his report to the other Heroes through Dispatch and puttering around the kitchen trying to make lunch that didn't taste of grass and terrible, Owen finally gave in to the Sunday laziness and sank into the couch, picked up the remote, and flipped through the channels.

He'd managed to burn through about half an hour when a vibration on his leg caught his attention. Pulling out his phone, Owen saw the recent text from Galvanize about moving the Monday morning meeting back an hour, then noticed one stamped a few hours prior. Evidently it had come when things were more hectic. Owen pressed the small mail icon and saw a message from Lenny pop up.

*Channel 44, 1:00 p.m. Don't miss it.*

Since the clock on his phone told Owen that it was already 1:23, he grabbed the remote and frantically began clicking through the channels, in such a hurry that the idea of punching in the numbers directly never even occurred to him. Arriving at last, he saw a stuffy, somewhat ruddy-faced man wearing what was clearly an expensive suit. For a moment, he was uncertain why Lenny wanted him to watch this dipshit, then a familiar voice came from off-screen and it all made sense.

"And what, pray-tell, is it you feel I should apologize for?"

The camera turned to Bubble Bubble, who looked as composed and put together as she'd ever been, a sharp contrast to the worn out man sitting across the desk from her. Owen stared at the screen, taking careful stock of his teammate. Something seemed slightly off about her. Same copper hair, same pale, freckled cheeks, same designer costume as she always wore. Then he looked in her eyes and it clicked. She wasn't being demur and careful, wasn't doing her best to be pretty yet inoffensive. Bubble Bubble was meeting her interviewer's gaze head on, her eyes flashing with a confidence and fire Owen couldn't recall ever witnessing in her before.

"Your position makes you a role model to countless little girls," the man said, his voice raised higher than was called for. Owen might have missed the beginning of the interview, but he had a solid hunch that it hadn't been going the way the host expected. "The least you can do is show remorse when you make a mistake."

"I tell you what, I'll be glad to make an apology." Bubble Bubble leaned slightly forward, graceful as a falling rose petal, and smiled charmingly. "Why don't you just tell me which part I should apologize for? Is it being lied to by a man who I only now know has a history of infidelity, or being naïve enough to trust someone I liked at his word? Perhaps you feel I owe everyone an apology for making a sober, informed decision to have sex with a fellow adult rather than stick to a centuries' outdated ideal of feminine chastity. Or do I owe an apology for not being sorry that I was tricked, for

standing up and refusing to let myself be blamed for another's actions? You tell me, Mr. Biron, which one I should apologize for. Explain it to me, and the viewers at home, and I'll be happy to say I'm sorry."

The station cut to a commercial quickly, though not quite before the interview's face grew a shade or two redder. As a commercial for dish soap began to play, Owen pressed a button on the still open phone in his hand, dialing up Lenny.

"Thought you'd have called earlier," Lenny said, picking up after only a single ring.

"Just got the text," Owen replied. "What in the hell did you tell that girl?"

"I told her the right call was to be aggressive and proud. She did nothing wrong, so instead of being conciliatory, she had to go on the attack. Show no shame, no fear, and keep calling out people for being assholes. Booked her on Robert Biron's show to test the waters; he's an aspiring talking head with too little brains to make it anywhere big. She's more or less been wiping the floor with him for the last half hour."

"Caught the tail end of a speech, I thought the guy was going to have a damn aneurysm," Owen said.

"This is only the beginning. If she keeps up doing this well, Bubble Bubble might just end up coming out ahead in this scandal. Speaking of, a little bird told me there was a lot of action around the Mordent building today. Anything your agent needs to be aware of?"

"No, for once this isn't my problem." As an ad for Hero-endorsed candy bars ended, Owen saw the now-familiar set reappear.

"Gotta let you go, Lenny. I don't want to miss a moment of this."

“All right team, this is going to be a big week for us.”

Galvanize was somehow awake and peppy on Monday morning without the aid of caffeine, a talent more than one person had theorized might be his actual super-power. Around him, the others looked more or less like half-risen zombies, save for Bubble Bubble, who seemed unusually chipper. Despite being pulled in for an “image consultation” with Mr. Greene after Sunday’s interview, it was evident she was still riding on high on her small victory and the hope that all was not entirely lost. Only time would tell if the strategy actually paid off, but Owen was content just to see life returning to her eyes. It was more than had been there before, in all honesty.

“The eighth annual Supers Care Charity Spectacular kicks off tomorrow at nine in the morning,” Galvanize continued. “Aside from dealing with emergencies, our schedules have been completely cleared out. No appearances, no interviews, no meetings, nothing. All Mr. Greene wants us to do is focus on the event and do our best to represent ourselves, and our sponsors, in a positive light.”

“Translation: we have no excuses for skipping out early when we get bored and tired,” Hexcellent mumbled, not bothering to try and actually avoid being heard.

“Mr. Greene simply wants to make it easy on us to focus,” Galvanize countered, treating her grumbling as though it had been a sincere concern. Owen had realized that this was one of Galvanize’s greatest tricks for handling the egos and whining of his teammates. By acting as though every petty complaint was a genuine issue, it essentially shamed the others into somewhat holding their tongues.

Galvanize reached under the kitchen table, which was laden with healthy-eating options brought in specifically for the Monday meeting. He pulled out a paper bag bearing a logo that said “SCCS” woven into a number eight. It only took a moment to put the meaning together, which gave everyone a clue as to what the packets Galvanize was pulling from the bag might relate to.

“These are your schedules for the coming four days. It tells you where to be for the individual events and contests you signed up for, as well as

directs you to places on site where we can rest and recover privately.” Galvanize began handing them out one at a time. Each team member’s name was scrawled in impressive calligraphy across the eggshell-colored envelope. “None of this should come as much surprise to you, as we all chose our activities ourselves; however, there are two exceptions I need to make you aware of. Mr. Greene felt it was important that we show a united presence and as such requested that we be registered for two team events.”

“Anyone else worried by the fact that he’s just telling us this now?” Zone ripped off the top of his envelope and began hurriedly sorting through pages until he found what he was looking for. “Are you shitting me, Galv? The tug-of-war?”

“It was chosen because all Supers, be they Heroes, athletes, or PEERS, can compete. Plus, it shows all of us working in tandem toward a common goal.”

“Yeah. . . do you even need us to call bullshit on that?” Hexcellent jerked a thumb at Owen, who was examining his packet of documents far more carefully than Zone. “They picked it because it’s a contest of pure strength, which means Titan can do all the work and we won’t look like dumb asses. It’s going to get us far, sure, but no one is going to be fooled into thinking we four did anything other than hold the rope.”

“There will be entire teams on the other end pulling against us,” Galvanize protested. “Even Titan can’t handle the task alone.”

“No, I probably can,” Owen replied, looking up from his pages at last. “I mean, depending on who they’ve got on the other teams. Anything is possible, but knowing the Heroes of Brewster, I’d lay pretty good odds that I can win that thing solo.” He glanced around at the others and gave a half-shrug of his shoulders. “Look, I didn’t ask for this crap any more than you did, but I may as well be honest about our chances of winning.”

“What’s the other event?” Bubble Bubble asked, her own packet resting untouched in front of her.

“A simple Q&A for those interested in going into the PEERS line of work,” Galvanize responded, clearly glad to be even momentarily off the tug-of-war topic. “Titan will be there to field questions from active Heroes who are interested in taking on Hero Liaison roles.”

Hexcellent snorted then snickered in a combination so perfect that everyone at the table instantly knew she’d practiced it. “Which means Titan

will get peppered with questions for half an hour while we sit around with our metaphorical dicks in our hands. The dudes could probably literally do that, too, and no one would even notice.”

Galvanize began to reply but stopped himself. He took a moment to look around the table at the faces of his team, and then sat down in the only open chair remaining at their breakfast table. “Look, the simple truth of this is that Titan is *far* more famous than the rest of us. You know it, I know it, and Mordent certainly knows it. So they want to put him out in front of the cameras as much as possible, with us right there alongside him to make sure the logos get seen. I’m not saying it’s going to be great, but it’s only two events. The rest of the time we get to do our own things.”

“Galvanize, chill,” Hexcellent told him. “No one’s actually pissed about the extra events. We know Titan is a fucking legend, and at this point, hanging out in his shadow can be kind of fun. We just didn’t want you trying to sell us shit by pretending it was chocolate.”

“Not how I would have put it, not even in the slightest, but I second the general sentiment,” Bubble Bubble said.

“I’m in for whatever the team wants,” Owen told them. “Technically, Mordent doesn’t have the right to sign me up for events I don’t agree to, so if you all aren’t feeling these two then I’ll drop out. Pretty sure they won’t try and force you four to handle them without me.”

“No, we should do them.” Zone lowered his packet, and, in a rare display, actually looked Owen in the eyes. “Who cares if it’s really all about you? That’s business as usual for us corpies. At least there’s the chance some good will come of these. And besides, I think we might not entirely hate the idea of spending a little time together at this thing. You know, as a team.”

Owen scanned the table, watching for dissent but finding only agreeable smiles and nodding heads. Personally, he wished they had asked him to call it off, at least the tug-of-war. He had a feeling that SAA members and Heroes weren’t going to take well to losing to one washed up Hero and his team of corpies. But what his team wanted, Owen would deliver.

“Tell Mordent we’re good to go,” Owen said, looking over at Galvanize. “And ask them if I’ve gotten any mail yet today. If we’re spending most of the week out in public, I’d better get my new uniforms pressed.”





Owen was surprised by the knock at his door. Given the team's busy day of helping out at a multicar pileup, not to mention the upcoming public spectacle, he'd expected everyone to have already hit the showers and be heading to sleep. Getting up from his bed carefully, he walked over and pulled open the door to find Hexcellent standing on the other side.

For a moment, Owen didn't even recognize the thin, pale young woman in front of him, as it was the first time he'd ever seen her face free from its caked layers of makeup. Adding in that she was adorned in a t-shirt bearing Spyda and his band along with a pair of sweatpants, she could have easily passed as a different person. In spite of all the moaning and complaining about Mordent and the rules, she was possibly the most dedicated to never being seen out of character.

She looked younger than usual and a bit more frail, as though he were seeing her without her armor for the first time. The impression of weakness was quickly shattered as she strode past him, scanned the meager room, and let out a sharp whistle. "Man, they really fucked you good on the accommodations, huh? Pretty sure this was a storage room back when Mirror Fog worked here."

"Was it now?" Owen had known from day one Greene was sending a message, but he hadn't imagined the corporate puppet had gone quite so far to send it. "What's up kid, can't sleep?"

"Yeah, they make drugs for that," Hexcellent replied. "I just wanted to see what you had scheduled around eleven tomorrow." Reaching into the pocket of her sweatpants, she pulled out a half-crumpled piece of paper and tried to smooth it out. "I've got a gap in ye olde schedule, and if we do lunch together in public then Greene can't really bitch about me eating from the food stands that will be there. I mean, team solidarity and supporting a good cause, that's two fucking birds right there."

Owen repressed a chuckle and went across to his dresser, picking up the packet and pulling his own schedule out of it. By the time he turned back around, Hexcellent had crossed the room and was now examining the pair of pictures on his desk. She glanced up, stared at him for a long moment, then looked back down.

“Were you wearing a wig in these? Your hair is way longer, but you look almost exactly the same.”

“Those photos were taken over ten years ago.” Owen moved to join her, staring down at his sons. It was hard to believe so much time had passed. He could still remember watching Roy struggle to get the washing machine off the ground, then slowly moving it higher and higher. By the time he’d managed to hold it over his head, the kid was so proud he may as well have been Atlas holding the earth. And Hershel, nervous as could be to speak in front of all those people at the spelling bee, had still pushed through. What he lacked in strength, Hershel easily made up for in heart and guts.

“Ten years?” Hexcellent looked back and forth again then stood up straight. “Are you a fucking Highlander?”

“Just a Super whose body does not want to play along with the aging process,” Owen replied. He tried not to think about his body’s rebuffing of something as natural as growing older. It meant that there was no peaceful end in sight somewhere down the line. The only options were to be killed or to keep living until it became a curse. At least there were Supers out there who could kill him. After so many years of being untouchable, Owen actually took a measure of comfort in that knowledge.

“Damn. The kids still that age too?”

“No, they’ve both grown up into fine young men.” Owen smiled, unable to suppress the fatherly pride that beamed within him. Even if they hated him until the end of time, he would never stop being proud of what his sons had made of their lives. “They’re my kids, actually. Going through the HCP right now.”

“Oh yeah, I saw some videos speculating about what would happen to your family after. . . well, you know, the fucking another dude thing.”

“I’m familiar with it, yes.”

“So are they like you? Immortal little bad asses destined to whip the shit out of every bad guy who crosses their path?” Hexcellent stepped away from the picture slightly, more interested in Owen’s current expression than his photographed past.

“They’re similar, but with gifts all their own.” Owen shook his head, still looking at the boys as he’d remembered them until they came striding into his bar looking for answers. “But they’re better than me by a mile. Those

two are going to make the world a more decent place, in and out of costume.”

“In costume? Ah, I get you. Titan’s kids in the HCP. Bet they’re knocking the teeth out of all the other students.”

“The HCP isn’t as cut and dry as you might think,” Owen told her. “Even I got knocked around in my early days. It’s not as much about the beatings, but what you learn from them. Actually, I’m hoping to get time off in a few months to go watch their end of the year exam, assuming Greene doesn’t find a way to keep me penned up here.”

“As long as you put on a good show this week, I bet you’ll be able to swing a favor or two,” Hexcellent advised. “And if worse comes to worse, ask Galvanize for the time instead of Greene. Fearless leader has a knack for making the suit come around.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.” Owen realized he was still holding his paper, so he pulled it up to check the time Hexcellent had asked about. “Looks like I’m free from ten to noon. Lunch at eleven, then?”

“Kickass, I’ll meet you at the entrance to the food alley.” Hexcellent pulled out another piece of paper, this one diagramming the different eating options available to those attending the charity event. She skimmed it with a growing expression of delight. “I say we hit the cotton candy and funnel cakes first.”

“That’s your idea of lunch?”

“That’s my idea of what I’m eating with my very rare access to a free pass.”

Owen glanced down at his schedule once more, the unmistakable sense that he was being played creeping into his mind. “You’re going to get me in trouble, aren’t you?”

“Fuck yeah I am.” Hexcellent turned and headed out the door, but turned back around and gave Owen a genuine smile. “But hey, you’ve only got yourself to blame. Before you showed up, there wasn’t any trouble to get in.”

Then she was gone, leaving Owen torn between whether he should feel complimented or worried by her statement. Ultimately, he settled on the former.



The hectic, half-mad energy of the sprawling grounds felt strangely familiar to Owen as he rode past the few security barriers, crammed with the rest of his team into the Mordent-issued SUV. Once upon a time, Titan had been a mainstay at many such events, putting on displays of strength and signing autographs until his pens ran dry, all in the name of giving back to the community. Many of his fellow Heroes undertook such activities as necessary obligations, something to generate good PR and make their agents happy. And, in total truth, Owen hadn't been so different from them when he first started doing Hero work. That changed when he found out about Hershel and Roy's status as Powered. Suddenly all those unfortunate souls he'd had the chance to help seemed closer to family than strangers.

As they cruised past various stalls and tents being set up on the Brewster fairgrounds, which the city generously allowed for the SCCS's use, Owen felt pangs of both nostalgia and regret. While it was good to be back in a position where he could make a difference, the weight of all his years pissed away on seclusion and self-pity weighed heavy on his heart. He looked away from the window, turning his attention to the team that was excitedly gabbing inside the vehicle.

To them, none of this was familiar in the slightest. Mordent had put them in charity events before, but never one as big as what they were currently heading into. It just hadn't made fiscal sense; few corpies had any fans that would want to see them, and their powers generally weren't strong enough to compete with Heroes and professional athletes in a meaningful way. Sending them into situations like this was a good way to make a team look foolish while also tearing down their self-esteem. Unless, of course, they had a big wave of public accolades to ride or a very famous Hero backing them up. Even so, Owen knew Mordent was taking a risk putting them out there like this. Most likely, they were counting on him to keep his team looking—and more importantly feeling—good.

Thus far it was an easy job. Zone was listing all the events he wanted to watch rapid-fire, Galvanize was reminding everyone to stay ahead of schedule whenever possible, Hexcellent was almost leaning out the window as she tried to catch sight of food trucks setting things up, and even Bubble Bubble seemed cheery as she spotted the occasional famous Super. Everyone

was in costume, under strict orders not to be out of them unless they were safely inside the penthouse. Given that some of their activities were going to be physical, sweaty, and downright dirty, Owen imagined whoever did the team's laundry was in for a hellish week.

At last the SUV angled into a covered parking area near the rear of the fairgrounds. Following the direction of several men in vests, Galvanize pulled into a large parking spot and killed the engine, then swiveled in place to face his team.

"All right, what're everyone's first events? Hexcellent?"

"Fiery Discussion is sponsoring a temporary tattoo booth where I'm going to stand around and help people pick what designs they want." She watched as Galvanize began to open his mouth then cut him off. "And the designs have to be on the pre-approved board. I am not allowed to try and talk anyone into making the artist draw a dick on their face, no matter how funny I think it would be."

"Very good. Bubble Bubble?"

"Cosmetics company is doing a raffle for free makeovers. I'm there to sell tickets and answer basic questions about the products."

Galvanize nodded. "Given your extra burst of notoriety, Mr. Greene approved having some plainclothes security stationed nearby, just in case anyone decides to forget that we're all here for charity."

"I'll stop by when I've got downtime too," Owen promised. Bubble Bubble gave him a grateful look and seemed to relax visibly. In his experience, people tended to use a lot more manners when staring up at a tree-trunk of a man who could juggle cars like cotton balls.

"On that note, Titan, can you remind us what you'll be doing with the morning?" Galvanize asked.

"Private panel for new Heroes, ones still in or only a few years out of their internships," Owen replied. "They're paying to get in and ask some of us experienced folks questions and advice for a couple of hours."

"Hot damn, that sounds cool," Hexcellent said. "Who else is in there besides you?"

"Not a clue," Owen admitted. "I was the first name on the list when we signed up, and I sort of forgot about all this anyway, so I never checked to

see who came after me. I'm assuming some people did, though, otherwise they'd have canceled the damn thing."

"I wouldn't be too sure about that," Galvanize told him. "Plenty of people would pay good money to learn from your experience alone. All right Zone, you're the last one, tell me you remember where you're supposed to go."

"Like I could forget." Zone leaned back in his chair and set his sneakered feet up on the SUV's dashboard. "Punch Juice is teaming up with a sports equipment company, so I've got to be on hand demoing what their stuff can do in order to get people to buy it. Which, by the way, I'm logging as work-out hours."

Galvanize reached over and swept Zone's legs down from the dash before responding. "I'm sure Mr. Greene will have no objection to that, since you are burning calories." He looked away from Zone, making sure to meet the eyes of each member of his team at least once. "Now everyone, today is basically a warm-up. All the events are small and simple, with none of the showy stuff scheduled to start until at least tomorrow. Use this time to get familiar with the area and plan your routes for the more hectic days. Remember, we're here on the job, and everything we do reflects on our team and sponsors."

"Hey fearless leader, since we had to be quizzed on our schedules, what are you doing with your morning?" Hexcellent asked.

"I will be spending my morning at a meeting for organizers and team leads. Lots of slides, handouts, and boring details. Anyone who dislikes their plans up for trading jobs with me?"

Deafening silence was the only reply, and Galvanize allowed himself a smug smirk in the privacy of their SUV.

"I thought not. Now everyone get out there and do your best!"

Owen made his trip through the fairgrounds as quickly and covertly as a man made of muscle and bordering seven feet tall was capable. Thankfully, the team had arrived early enough that the majority of others in attendance were either workers getting the booths set up or fellow Supers who were preparing for their own morning activities. Many, some Heroes and no doubt a few corpies, were in costume, but by far the majority of attendees wore uniforms from their respective Super Athletics Association teams. Just in his immediate proximity, Titan spotted several Fort Worth Juggernauts, a couple of the Tampa Atlanteans, and one relatively massive quarterback from the L.A. Crushers.

While Owen took in the crowd, it was also clear the crowd was taking in him. The more polite ones simply glanced in his direction and looked away, but a few felt free to stare at the famous, disgraced Hero hurrying through the grounds. As for the Hero himself, he dearly wished he'd paid more attention to the map in his schedule packet. For the most part, people kept their conversations about him whispered low enough to where he was unable to hear them, thankfully. On occasion, though, a word would rise up to greet his ears, and it was rarely a kind one.

His brisk pace waned as Owen forced himself to slow down. This wasn't a mission or rescue where he could get in and get out. He and his team were going to be here for several days. This walk was likely to be the easiest one he'd have in that entire time; at least these people felt some professional courtesy towards him. If he wanted to get through it, Owen would have to do more than act like it wasn't bothering him; he would actually have to not let it bother him. He'd known this was part of what he was walking back into when he put on the mask; there was no wiggling out now.

Taking his time, moving slowly across the grounds, it took only a few more minutes of searching before he found the small building where he was supposed to do the morning's panel. Old, brick, and no doubt built for some utilitarian purpose long before Brewster converted this area to fairgrounds, it was still a high step up from the open tents that were being set up all around him. Near the front entrance, a small line of people in costumes was already forming. People younger than some of Owen's teammates stood milling about in the morning sun. He was a bit surprised at the number; Brewster alone



didn't have this many interns or rookies. Seemed folks from out of town had traveled in for the event, which made Owen worry all this might be a bigger deal than he'd realized.

Pushing that thought out of his mind, he made his way around to the back entrance before anyone spotted him. He gave a polite nod to the lone worker stationed at the rear, a teenaged girl who looked to be in awe of all the famous figures around her, then pushed his way through the door and into the building. Owen had barely made it five steps before he heard a familiar, though not altogether friendly, voice call to him.

"Well I'll be. Seems you really did sign up for this event. Aether was certain someone had put your name down as a joke." Gale, fully-costumed and a bit bleary-eyed from the early hour, stood from her small metal folding chair and walked over to Owen, giving his hand a quick shake as soon as they drew close.

"I wasn't certain. I just said it seemed unlikely that he'd choose to spend time at such an unremarkable venue," Aether corrected. She didn't rise from her seat, but she did give Owen a polite nod and gentle smile.

There were two more open chairs sitting at the long table that stretched across the makeshift stage, one far larger than the others and made of reinforced material, clearly set up with Titan's renowned size in mind. Counting Gale and Aether, that made for a panel of four: a healthy size given the intimate setting and small room. In just the three Heroes present, there was also a large amount of power and career diversity. Gale was the leader of a team that had been passed down for decades, and a powerful elemental manipulator to boot. Aether could speak about running a team with unusual power sets, as Transcendental Justice was an effective, if unorthodox, composition of Heroes. Owen himself had the experience to talk about what it was to be a strongman, to run a team, to fall from the public's grace, and to work as a Hero Liaison. The only area they'd need help to cover in order to answer all the questions these kids might have was Subtlety.

"I do not, for the life of me, know how you lot put up with arriving early to these things. Time is too precious to be pissed away on waiting around."

Owen did a half-turn, already knowing who he would find. Sure enough, standing there in the sort of simple, unremarkable costume that was the fashion with many Subtlety Heroes, stood Jeremiah. It looked strange on him, and it took Owen a minute to realize that this was the first time he'd ever

seen Jeremiah in full gear, out in the field. Every other time they'd met he'd been behind the scenes, not out in public. Having finally seen him in costume, Owen could easily say that the other version suited him far better.

There was little doubt Jeremiah agreed as he tugged at his mask and collar, clearly uncomfortable in the elaborate get up. That didn't stop him from greeting Gale and Aether before finally making his way through the room and arriving in front of Owen.

"Ready to dole out the pearls of wisdom from years of accolades and fuck ups?"

"As ready as I can be when I have no idea what the kids are going to ask me. Haven't exactly done one of these in a while, and I've been out of the field for a long time," Owen admitted.

"Please, the questions out of the newbies' mouths never change. They'll ask about how whether to pick a team or create one, what it was like to fight some criminal that we don't remember but they studied meticulously, and if we have any tips for not dying. Same stuff we asked about when we were doing internships." Jeremiah paused, glancing toward the front door where soon a dozen or so young Heroes would come streaming in. "Just try and make them feel at ease. Nothing we say in these things is likely to make much of a difference in the field, but we can at least give them some hope and confidence. That's what they really came out for."

"I'll keep that in mind." Owen could hear the bustling of moving feet, a clear indicator that the door had just been opened. "Glad you were able to come out as well. All of you, really. I can't remember the last time I saw one of these with three different team leaders on it."

"You're the one to thank for that," Jeremiah replied, heading toward his seat. "We were approached about filling out the empty slots after so many others turned it down. Or did you think it was coincidence that the only people willing to sit on a panel with you, to be publicly associated with such a polarizing figure, were the ones who had personally worked with you before?"

Owen stared at the drably-costumed man as he walked away, then took his own reinforced seat. It was nice to walk slow, keeping his chin up and trying to be strong, but he also couldn't forget how most of the Hero world still viewed him: nothing but a scandal and a fuck up.

He tried to keep that thought out of his head as the first costumed

body entered the room and made a beeline for the front row.

## 81.

“Today, we’re here to talk to you about what comes next. While you had ample time to go over the Hero occupation and our world during the time you spent at your respective HCPs, by now you’ve all gotten at least a few months of real world experience under your belt. As such, the questions and concerns that you have now are likely different from a student’s, who had only theoretically delved into what it means to be a Hero.” Gale’s voice rang through the small building easily, keeping every back straight and ear attentive. Owen had to admit: whatever bad blood had passed them between since he arrived, there was no question that the woman could command a room.

“Now, we are not here to contradict your mentors; they are, of course, the best font of wisdom any of you has access to. But, that said, no Hero has experienced every aspect of this life personally. We may have different answers regarding different specialties or career paths than your mentors did. Please ask anything you like, though I do recommend you keep all inquiries respectful. Regardless of what our individual pasts may be, we are all up here because we have wisdom to share.” Speech done, Gale took her own seat and motioned to the event worker who was standing down near the front of the audience with a clipboard.

The woman hurried forward so fast she nearly fell over, scanning down her clipboard and calling out a name. A young woman wearing a bright uniform that seemed to span the entire color spectrum rose from her seat near the back and walked briskly to the front as the worker ticked the name off the list. Ordinarily, this was where the enterprising Hero would have been given a microphone, but in such a small space, utilizing audio equipment was a waste of money.

“Hi there. I’m Lorikeet. Korman Graduate and second year intern. My question was for Aether. Are there many teams out there like Transcendental Justice, or did you found yours because there was no other fit for you?”

Given Lorikeet’s odd name and stranger costume, Owen had a hunch that the question was more personal than academic. While many Supers fell into easily classifiable categories where they could be lumped together, the fact that no two were ever completely alike could lead to some strange powers. Lorikeet was either very smart or very strong; she’d have never made

it out of the HCP without one of those traits. That didn't necessarily mean her power would easily fit into an existing team's dynamic, though.

As Aether talked about founding her team cooperatively with the rest of her group, being chosen as leader by a vote she had no hand in, Owen's thoughts drifted back to the founding of the Gentle Hammers. Unlike those with odd powers, any of the Hammers could have easily been worked in to any other team's arsenal; there was never a shortage of need for those who could lift trucks and shrug off bullets. Still, they'd decided to band together anyway, opting to go out and try and run things their way rather than being relegated to the role of mindless muscle, a stereotype thrust on strongmen since the earliest days of Hero work.

The sound of applause jerked Owen out of his stupor, and he realized that Aether had finished her response. He joined in the clapping, better late than never, as Lorikeet headed back to her seat and a young man wearing a black and gold color scheme stepped forward. There was something a bit archaic about the design woven into his costume, though Owen didn't have the historical sense to place where it was from. When the man reached the front, he scanned the panel, eyes narrowing a touch when he saw Titan, then continuing on until he was staring Jeremiah dead on.

"My name is Hop-Frog, and yes, it's after the Poe story. First year intern, graduated from West Private University. My question is for Jeremiah. As a fellow Subtlety Hero and a proud gay man, did you find the Hero world a welcoming place once you were out of your intern years?"

"Hell no," Jeremiah replied immediately. "And it started long before I got out of my internship. But if I'm being honest here, the Subtlety thing has been far more a roadblock for me than being gay. Lots of Hero teams out there understand what it is we do and bring to the table, so they'll let us join up, but it's always with that attitude. 'Letting us,' like we're being done a favor by getting the chance to come on board and help save lives while keeping our team safe. I'm not going to paint with a wide brush and say every team is this way; in fact, I know firsthand that the Subtlety Hero on Transcendental Justice considers herself a valued member of the group. That said, it's still the way of thinking in a lot of the older, more established teams. Your options are either to put up with it, find a group that treats you right, or start your own damn team. In case you couldn't tell, I opted for the latter."

Hop-Frog started to head back to his seat, but Jeremiah held up a hand to stop him. "Now, as for how being gay has impacted my career, I won't

sugarcoat that either. There have been times when I could have signed on to teams with clout and prestige, and all I would have had to do is put up with some other member who had very firm thoughts about people's sexuality. Luckily, I had enough pull to tell them to go fuck themselves, but that's not the case for everyone. And this has gotten much better as time passed and the older opinions died out. Were I trying to make it as an openly gay Hero even a few decades back, it probably would have been a whole different story. Back then, even admitting a simple truth about yourself cost people their entire life's work. It forced a lot of good people to live lies, all so they could keep doing what they loved: keeping innocent people safe."

His speech over, Jeremiah lowered his hand and let the intern hustle back to his seat. The worker called another up another Hero, who scrambled down the aisle. Up on stage, Owen looked down to Jeremiah, who made no effort to meet his eyes. Though Titan hadn't been mentioned once in the discussion, there was no doubt in anyone's mind what Jeremiah had been really talking about. It was a kind, unexpected show of unity.

And a nice reminder to Owen that not everyone wearing a mask thought the worst of him.

After the panel wrapped, there was a quick flurry of goodbyes as the others had to hurry off to their teams or next events. Unlike Owen, they were still immersed in the life, and that meant downtime was a rare commodity. It was an aspect of being a full-time Hero he remembered fondly, yet wasn't particularly burning to recapture. Perhaps it was age, or more likely the perspective that came with living through the years, but Owen was content to spend a portion of his time outside the field. At least, so long as he had his team to spend it with.

He flipped through his schedule to see what was next on the agenda. Lunch with Hexcellent wouldn't be for another hour, unless she managed to slip out early, which seemed like at least a fifty percent shot. After that he just had some minor personal appearance work until things wound down. Galvanize hadn't been lying; the first day really was set up to be light and let everyone get comfortable. Lacking anything pressing, Owen decided to make good on his word and go check on Bubble Bubble. The guards Mordent had paid for were no doubt top notch, but that wasn't really why he needed to be there. Owen was meant to be a comforting presence for her more than a deterrent for someone with a lot of lip and little wit.

Weaving his way through the myriad of tents and booths that were still springing up like weeds, it took Owen a good fifteen minutes to find Bubble Bubble's booth. Once he did, however, there was no mistaking it for any other. The fact that she was standing in front of it certainly helped, but not as much as the half-dozen reporters holding cameras and swarming around her. She was inexpressive, face well-controlled as she talked to a handsome man wearing clothes that probably cost more than Owen's first car.

Whatever they were saying was lost as Owen moved closer. The other reporters caught sight of the massive man's approach and hurried over; Bubble Bubble and her debate partner were half-dragged along with them. Cameras were raised and small microphones thrust upward as they tried to surround him.

"Titan! Any comment on Corbin Calhoun's claims that your teammate has fabricated her telling of the events?"

"Do you know Bubble Bubble to be a habitual liar, or is this her first

time?”

“Have you seen her use powers to manipulate other men?”

Owen nearly took a step back, bowled over by the wave of questions and accusations, especially since it was the first time he could remember that they weren't all barbs aimed at him. To his great surprise, he wished they were. At least he was used to this sort of scrutiny; he'd far rather handle it than let it fall on Bubble Bubble's shoulders. His eyes swept the small crowd once more, and this time they locked on the handsome man with the wide, clearly artificial smile. This no doubt was Corbin Calhoun, the one who made so much trouble for Bubble Bubble, who had apparently shown up to ambush her and undermine her efforts at fixing her image. It was a bold move; Owen had to give him that. Ordinarily, he respected bold moves. Today, he was feeling less charitable.

“Whoa now. Getting in to ‘he said, she said’ arguments is no good for anyone,” Owen replied, raising his hands and gently parting the crowd. He stepped through them, getting between Bubble Bubble and Corbin then laying a hand on each of their shoulders. “I know Bubble Bubble to be an honest, capable young woman who has never given me any reason to doubt her.”

Corbin opened his mouth, and Owen squeezed ever-so-slightly, using all the self-control he had to keep from snapping this man's bones beneath his fingers. “But I also want to take this chance to pay my respects to Mr. Calhoun, who is showing the Hero community so much faith and respect with his recent accusations.”

“Excuse me, he's *what*?” Bubble Bubble snapped, whipping her head up to stare at Owen, who merely smiled knowingly at her before returning his gaze to Corbin.

“Corbin Calhoun is a brave man, one who clearly believes in the Heroes and what they stand for. Most people would be too afraid to make such bold, viral accusations about Supers keeping their ‘secret powers’ hidden from the world. Insinuating that a woman who uses her clearly-documented abilities to help save lives is also concealing powers of mental manipulation is, to be frank, illogical and unfounded. Mr. Calhoun, however, has chosen to exercise his freedom of speech, even though doing it like this is likely to draw the ire of every one of the pro-Super organizations and syndicates out there, legal and otherwise. Mr. Calhoun is trusting in us, in the Hero system, to keep him safe from all those people, even as he slanders our very species, and I want to thank him for that. It shows that he completely trusts in the Heroes of



this great country, and believes that we will be able to keep him safe.”

The blood from Corbin’s face had begun to drain halfway through Owen’s speech, and as he stared up at the seemingly genuine smile plastered on Titan’s face, his legs wobbled the slightest bit. It was only Owen’s powerful hands that kept the man from fainting outright. Titan held him up through the dizzy spell until the world famous director had partially recovered.

“Anyway, if you’ll excuse us, I just came to get my teammate for a quick briefing. Duty always calls, you know how it is.” Owen released Corbin, who was swarmed by reporters as Owen carefully led Bubble Bubble away from the booth. Her guards tried to follow, but he waved them off. She needed some space, and he aimed to give it to her.

“Titan. . . was that a threat?” Bubble Bubble glanced over her shoulder to where the small crowd of reporters had turned on the man who brought them, shaking her head as if she couldn’t believe what had just happened.

“It was simply the truth. There are groups out there who take umbrage with Supers being slandered, and not all of them are the type to handle things legally. I doubt any would really have the balls to go after that high profile of a target, but you never know. He’s certainly not helping himself,” Owen explained.

“Yeah, but it still really felt like you were threatening him. I can’t point to a word you used, or anything you did, I just know if I’d been in his shoes I think I might have pissed myself.”

“Don’t sell yourself short,” Owen told her. “You’d have held up far better than he did. Now, let’s go duck into the private parking area, then I’ll grab Hexcellent and we’ll all go get cheese fries.”

Bubble Bubble laughed softly and patted Owen on the arm. “You are nothing like the Titan I first expected.”

Owen grinned, nothing like the fake smile he’d shown Corbin and the reporters, and gave her a quick side-armed hug. “That might be the nicest thing anyone on this team has said to me.”

Lunch was a longer affair than Owen expected, though he really should have been prepared for such: Hexcellent had every intention of eating her way through the fair under the guise of team building. By the time she was finally done, a small stack of greasy paper plates had been collected in her hands like trophies: trophies she quickly dumped into a trash can as she hurried to her next event. Bubble Bubble, having taken the opportunity to down a funnel cake and corn dog herself, also returned to her booth once she got word the reporters had cleared out.

Owen, once again with time on his hands, took the chance to actually stroll through the event and check out some of the various attractions. He was getting accustomed to the stares and whispers, so much so that there were times he didn't even notice them. Instead, he focused on the bevy of booths and tents spread across the landscape, gazing in wonderment at the well-organized attractions meant to wring as much money as possible for charity.

Autograph booths were by far the most popular and frequent attractions, spread carefully across the fairgrounds so that the sprawling lines didn't cause a complete bottleneck. Just as in the morning, the vast majority of these were manned by Supers from various sports teams, mostly younger players of whom Owen was only cursorily aware.

As he walked by an area devoid of people but roped off in preparation for what would be a massive, snaking line, Owen caught sight of a very familiar name emblazoned across the banner stretched above the lone table at the end of the line. The Comet, Jade Norris, was going to be present on the final day for an autograph session. Now retired, she was still a legend in her own right, and Owen found himself flipping through his schedule to see if he had any free time that day. Maybe if he could get here early enough, he could snag the former football star's autograph. One look at the heavily-inked block of activities made it clear that he'd be lucky to squeeze in time to piss; standing in a massive line was way out of the question. Pity. Owen had a feeling that would have been quite the thrill.

Just past the area blocked off for Jade's signing Owen spotted a familiar figure slipping into a white tent with a red cross on it. He contemplated pretending not to have noticed, but then headed toward it anyway. If someone was hurt, he felt like he should acknowledge it, even if

that person was Zone.

Owen pulled back the medical tent's flap to reveal a wide space filled with air-conditioning units and cots. Most were empty, though a couple hosted people who looked as though they'd had too much sun, fun, or rum and were trying to sleep it off. In the corner, resting a large bag of ice against his left knee, was Zone, who balked as soon as he saw Owen's massive silhouette in the entrance. Zone didn't bother trying to run or flee; he merely tried to look as sullen as possible while Owen carefully made his way through the tent.

"Hurt yourself already? It's only the first day." Owen didn't bother pointing to the ice bag; they both knew why Zone was here.

"It's preventative, not that this is any of your business," Zone snapped. "I have to ice my knees between events so I can make it through everything. Doctor's orders."

"Uh huh. I'm pretty sure the docs' preference was that you not do any of this stuff, not just keep your knees cold." Owen crossed his arms deliberately and stared down at the much smaller man. "What's the deal with this, anyway? Will Mordent really not spring for a healer? I mean, you've got a lot of sponsors. It seems like a worthwhile investment."

Zone puffed up for a moment, ready to be combative, but as he shifted the bag from his right knee to his left the wind seemed to drift out of his sails. "They. . . they've healed me before. A few times, actually. The problem is that this isn't just one injury that can be easily fixed. It's the culmination of a lifetime full of putting constant strain on my body. Unlike some people, there's nothing really special about my physique, just in how I use it. Little injuries keep piling up, and by the time a healer comes around, the damage is already done."

"And total-body, retroactive healers are as rare as they are expensive," Owen said, understanding setting in. Healers, like all Supers, had highly individual powers. They were already a fairly uncommon breed, and the ones who could do more than just accelerate a body's natural recovery were a step above. Getting rid of injuries after they'd already healed on their own. . . there were probably fewer than ten known Supers in the world with that kind of power, all of them in high demand. Even if it could book one, Owen doubted Mordent was willing to fork over the cash it would take just to turn back the clock on a single asset.

“You’ve got it. So I’m stuck icing my knees and powering through, at least for as long as this body of mine is willing to hold out.” Zone shifted the bag once more; clearly his right knee was the one more in need of treatment.

“I can see that. I suppose asking if you’ve thought about hanging it up before you tear yourself apart would be a waste of my breath,” Owen said.

“Not all of us get to do this for as long as we want,” Zone replied. “Getting a taste of what it’s like to be out there, making a difference, doing things that only we can. . . for a lot of us it’s fleeting. One day, when these things finally give out on me, I’ll have to settle for some corporate gig, probably take a job for Mordent helping oversee new corpies. But until then I can still work. I’d rather spend the rest of my time doing the job I love than watching from the sidelines. But I guess you probably wouldn’t understand that.”

There was no right answer Owen could give, not to Zone, so he didn’t bother. Instead, he merely walked across the medical tent, filled up a fresh bag with ice, and brought it over to his teammate. Wordlessly, he took the melting bag away and handed Zone the fresh one. Only when the new bag was in place did Owen speak, and it was with a more subdued tone than Zone had ever heard from the large man’s mouth.

“You’re not wrong. I’ve got no place to lecture you on how you spend what time you’ve got, not after I wasted so many of my years. But I’ve seen a lot of good people die because they couldn’t let go when their bodies were no longer capable of doing the job. It’s a damned shame to see that happen. What’s worse, though, is that there are people counting on the ones who die. . . innocent civilians who were expecting to be saved but got left in the fire because someone unable to admit their time was up took the call instead of letting it go to a person still capable. Just remember, Zone, your job doesn’t exist in vacuum. Your team and the people we go out there to help all depend on you. When the day comes that your body does finally give out, you might not be the only one who pays for that failure.”

Before Zone could respond, Owen turned and headed out of the tent. There was no trying to drill the point in, not with someone so stubborn. Heaven only knew how many people Owen had seen ignore the warning before.

All he could do was hope that Zone would be smarter.



When the rest of his team headed back to the Mordent penthouse, eager to relax and prepare for the next day's activities, Owen took a quick jog across town to a different destination. The evening air was cool against his face as he ran. He nodded his head to those who waved at his familiar costume as he passed them by. Near the day's end, Dispatch had passed on a message from Jeremiah that another meeting was set to take place. Owen was surprised at how eager he was to attend, and not just because of his curiosity about what the hell these robots were up to, either. Owen was getting a bit of a thrill from the chase. Working with his team was great and rewarding, but Titan hadn't been a legend for no reason. Deep down, Owen Daniels loved Hero work, and hunting the bots was reminding him why.

Instead of a hotel, this time Jeremiah had them meeting in the upstairs of a store that seemed to sell nothing but smoked meats and whiskey. Owen circled around the back, climbing the rickety staircase and easing past the slightly-rotted wooden door. It seemed Jeremiah hadn't been kidding about his team's need to meet in different places; this was about as far from a five-star penthouse as he could get.

Stepping into the surprisingly-spacious room, Owen quickly realized that he was the last to arrive. Deadlift, Aether, and Gale were all sitting in fold-out chairs, staring at the projector's screen that Jeremiah had positioned himself next to. The Subtlety Hero smiled as Owen entered, motioning for him to shut the door.

"And at last, the great Titan has arrived to bless us with his presence. I'd offer you a seat, but the owners only had the three chairs on hand."

"Did you run all the way here or something?" Gale added. "We got the call over half an hour ago."

"Actually. . . yeah, I just jogged over." Owen slunk toward the back, towering over the other seated Heroes and positioning himself carefully so as not to block their view.

"You're joking," Aether said. "I know not every team has a teleporter, but surely you've at least got a car."

"Well, the team does, but I let them take it back home," Owen

admitted.

“Wow.” Jeremiah shook his head, half in amazement and half in disbelief. “That’s something one of us should do something about. If there’s a situation where we have to call in Titan, I doubt we’ll have time for him to take the shoe-leather express.”

“It’s worked fine so far,” Owen said.

“Ah, but I fear things are about to get more complicated, if not outright dangerous.” Jeremiah clicked a button on the remote clutched in his fingers; an image appeared on his projector screen. It showed a map of Brewster, complete with a dozen or so small red dots scattered throughout. “As you all know, the robots we’ve been dealing with broke their usual pattern last week, using decoys to attack us while they looted technology from a local company. Since then, there have been sporadic break-ins throughout the city, all at places specializing in either high-tech research or materials. No security camera footage has been recovered, not a single witness has come forward, and most distressing of all, the strikes have always come at times when Heroes are occupied or scattered.”

“Hold on, if no one has seen the perpetrators, how do we know it’s the robots?” Deadlift asked. “All they did before was attack us, and now they turn to petty crime?”

“I assure you, there is nothing petty about the sorts of things they’ve been stealing,” Jeremiah replied. “And as for why we assume the bots are the culprits, I’ll admit that part is speculative. That said, it would explain the shift in their behavior. What we assumed were attacks meant to test out new models may, in fact, have been intended to test us. . . specifically, our individual response times and coordination. These robberies are hitting us in the metaphorical blind spots, which either means that someone is using extensive surveillance and planning to estimate our responding abilities, or the Dispatch system has been compromised. My team ruled out the latter possibility as soon as we suspected it.”

“Wait, did you actually meet Dispatch?” It was Aether who asked the question, but everyone in the room, Owen included, leaned slightly forward as they stared at Jeremiah. Despite a long, prestigious career as a Hero before his scandal, Owen had never met, nor heard of anyone else who had met, Dispatch. Whoever or wherever she was, it was a complete mystery even from the people she talked with daily.

“I . . . no, I did not,” Jeremiah admitted. “But people I trust went through the communication system and assured me everything was still secure. And if the actual Dispatch decided to turn against us, we’d be in for more trouble than just dealing with robots, theft, and assault. Thus, we assume they are avoiding us through the other method, which points squarely at our mechanical opponents.”

“What do you think they’re doing?” Gale asked. “It’s still a month out from the next attack in their pattern.”

“Yes, and that’s part of why I gathered you all here.” Jeremiah clicked the button once more, and a diagram of a small device took the place of the map with the red dots. “Titan has informed us of a piece in the puzzle we were previously unaware of, a stolen machine that allows the machines to act as a single unit split into multiple bodies. That knowledge forced us view their attacks as far more organized than we originally assessed, and from the new perspective, my team has crafted a fresh theory.”

Another click, this time showing a familiar model of the robots that Owen had fought on two occasions now. “At their last iteration, the bots were tough enough to injure multiple Hero teams and cause extensive damage. While we don’t know exactly what benchmark they were working toward, we do believe that in that attack they met it. Thus, having evolved to whatever necessary point they were aiming for, their methods switched in to gathering experimental technology and equipment. Essentially, the robots reached a baseline, and are now incorporating stolen assets into their already powerful forms.”

“Damn.” Gale leaned back in her chair as Jeremiah’s words washed over her. “You’re saying this next fight is going to be a tough one.”

“Worse.” Jeremiah made another click, and this time all that showed on the screen was a giant red question mark. “I’m saying that, now that their first pattern is broken, we have no way to know when or where the next attack will be coming from. Not only will these things be far more powerful than any iteration we’ve faced before, but they have already demonstrated the ability to blindside us. Their next strike, the most powerful one yet, will likely come with exactly zero warning or chance to prepare.”



“I really hope there’s some good news as well, and that you didn’t just call us all in to make sure we knew we were helpless.” Gale seemed unfazed by Jeremiah’s announcement, as did pretty much else in the room save for Deadlift. As the youngest Hero of the group, he’d let out an audible gasp of shock at the announcement, an act he was clearly regretting in the face of the other’s stoic reactions.

“Well, it might be good or bad. Sort of depends on how things go. But we definitely know *something*.” Jeremiah clicked away the question mark, revealing a diagram of a single red dot with dozens of arrows pointing to blue ones spread across a new map of Brewster. “While running all the robots from one device might allow for incredible levels of cooperation, information relay, and strategy, it does still come with one giant weakness: namely that all of your robots are being run from one single point.”

Aether nodded, quickly taking Jeremiah’s meaning. “Unlike before, when we thought each unit was self-contained, now we know there’s a central command system. Which means if we take that out, we end the entire threat with one blow.”

“I can always tell which teams employ their own Subtlety Heroes, even without the research,” Jeremiah said. “Aether has hit the nail dead on. Before, we were trying to track the robots’ points of origin or uncover their creator, assuming that once an attack started, the only way to end it was to break them all to pieces. Now we know there’s another option, as well as some method of remote relay being used to issue orders. One of my fellow Modus Operandi members is currently working on a device that will, in theory, allow us to trace the signal back to its origin point, assuming we can capture a robot that isn’t completely destroyed.”

More than a few sets of eyes glanced at Owen, who merely raised his wide shoulders in a mighty shrug. “Guessing there are other Heroes who might be able to manage that.”

“Speaking of Modus Operandi, when are we going to meet one of these other team members of yours?” Deadlift asked. “You all seem to be spearheading the research, but from what I’ve heard, you’re the only one of the group anyone ever talks to.”

“And that is for good reason,” Jeremiah said. “The less that is known about a Subtlety Hero, the better. We do our best work when no one is ever certain we’ve been there at all. That’s why I, as the most extroverted member, was chosen to be the face and mouthpiece of our group. It lets the others keep on task while protecting their privacy as much as possible.”

“Though if you ever really want to meet them, just hold an event with an open bar,” Gale added. “I’ve yet to meet the Subtlety Hero that won’t drink as much of the good liquor as possible if given half a chance.”

“Cruel, but not inaccurate,” Jeremiah said. “At any rate, you can trust that the man in charge of making the tracking device has the skills to make it work, assuming it’s doable in the first place. This means that when the attack does come, we will have Heroes functioning in two distinct capacities. Most will be tasked with bringing down the robots and protecting the civilians, but there will be a few of us whose jobs revolve around tracking their orders to the source. Once there, we’ll hopefully be able to put an end to these antics for good.”

“Why are we assuming they’ll attack?” Owen’s voice bounced off the bare wooden walls, no doubt echoing down to the smoked meat shop they were standing over even as the other Heroes turned in their chairs to face him. “Jeremiah said it himself: they’ve deviated from their old pattern. If all the other attacks were to refine their designs and figure out our weak spots, what does another fight gain for them?”

“That, my giant comrade, is the billion dollar question.” Jeremiah reached out and turned off the projector, his presentation having reached its end. “We know another attack is coming because most of the technology stolen during the break-ins was centered around weaponry or national defense. Not exactly the sorts of party favors one stocks up on if the battles are over. As to the why, that I genuinely have no answer for. If I knew, I’d be able to anticipate more and we wouldn’t be flying so blind. It’s possible Titan is right, with the pattern deviations there might not come any more battles. We may never see or hear from these damn robots again.”

“But you’re betting otherwise,” Gale surmised.

“I am. My team is. And we feel it behooves us to be as ready as possible when the time for action comes,” Jeremiah said.

“Then why are there only the five of us here?” Deadlift asked. “Shouldn’t you be getting the word out to as many Heroes as possible?”

“What word would that be, exactly?” Jeremiah countered. “That a giant, unpredictable attack may or may not be coming, and that if it does we have no idea when or where it will be from, nor will we know what the attacking enemies are capable of? I’ve just described every single day that a Hero wakes up to; nothing about that situation is novel. We five are here because, assuming you all accept, our task will be a different one. Should this strike come, I’ll be looking to you five to help me run down the device at the center of everything.”

“You’re picking an. . . interesting lineup.” Gale scanned the room with fresh eyes, lingering on Deadlift the longest as she took stock of her allies.

“Someone who can move through anything, someone who can lift anything, someone who can get anywhere, and someone who is functionally unstoppable.” Jeremiah ticked off their abilities on his fingers as he rattled them off one by one. “I dislike going into any situation without a veritable filing cabinet full of research and planning, but since I have to fly blind on this one, it only seemed prudent to pick Heroes whose combined abilities were up to any conceivable challenge, the majority of whom were seasoned warriors with excellent decision making skills.”

“It’s not a bad team, at least for infiltration,” Owen agreed. “If you need our help actually finding the place, though-”

“Thank you, but no. That much we’ll have well in hand,” Jeremiah assured him. “I just need to know if, should chaos rain down on us, you’ll be willing to come help me end it. This was what I hoped to accomplish today by making you all fully aware of the situation.”

“It’ll depend on the exact moment you call; I doubt any of us will leave our people in the lurch,” Gale said, rising from her seat. “But if I can swing it, I’ll come by.”

“Good to hear,” Jeremiah replied. “Perhaps you can pick up Titan, so we’re not stuck waiting for him to lightheartedly jog across the city.”

Owen's team was a touch more subdued as they pulled into the parking lot early for the Supers Care Charity Spectacular's second day. Now accustomed to their activities, they'd realized that, the setting aside, it wasn't really all that different from things they usually did when not on rescue calls: shake hands, pose for pictures, and make nice with the public. Besides, one day of sitting in those tents as guests walked by was all it took to remind them that they were secondary attractions. Between the sports stars and Heroes filling the ranks, few people even noticed that a team of corpies was present. While this should have been disheartening, it curiously had the opposite effect. Being out of the spotlight for a change took some of the pressure off and allowed them to enjoy themselves.

It had been a good call to spend a day getting settled, and Owen mentally tipped his cap to whoever had scheduled things out in such a way. As the crew unloaded from the SUV, however, Galvanize stopped them to deal with the one potential sore spot looming on their day's horizon.

"All right, everyone, you've all got your schedules and know where to head, but I want to make sure we're all clear on where to be at three this afternoon." Galvanize pulled out a printed map of the fairgrounds and pointed to a moderately-sized outdoor pavilion on the eastern side. "The panel starts at half past three, so we need to be there early to get ready."

Hexcellent stretched her hand in the air and waved it about, like a kindergartener racing the clock to get permission to use the restroom. "Can I be excused from that?"

"On what grounds?"

"On the grounds of BOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO." Dropping her arm from the air, Hexcellent cupped both hands around her mouth as she started to jeer, adding a bit of volume to her already impressive voice.

Galvanize, to his credit, stood patiently and waited until her booing slowly waned and faded out altogether. Only after silence had once again reasserted itself did he speak, and it was with the same calm voice he'd asked the initial question. "Was that you booing me, or an impression of what you think the crowd will do to us?"

“Either or. Pretty much take your pick,” Hexcellent replied.

“Despite what you might think, there is an abundance of Supers out there who want to use their abilities in less. . . martial capacities.” Galvanize’s eyes flitted to Owen, who kept his own face neutral. What Heroes did wasn’t always pretty, and sometimes it was downright horrifying; there was no pussyfooting around that. It was the unfortunate truth that, bad as what they sometimes had to do was, it was necessary.

“The chance at fame and money doesn’t hurt either,” Bubble Bubble added. “I’m sure we’ll get a fair amount of people who actually want to talk with us.”

“Thank you, Bubble Bubble,” Galvanize said.

“Of course, Hex is right too; we’re bound to get a few assholes, be they there for us or for Titan.” Bubble Bubble patted her massive teammate gently on the arm, not even making his elbow wobble.

“It’s a Q&A at a charity event. Anyone who can’t conduct themselves appropriately will be removed from the pavilion,” Galvanize told them. “Some of the burlier players from the SAA are also volunteering their time as security.”

“Guess we better hope they’re tougher than anyone who starts shit.” Zone made his way around the SUV more slowly than any of the others, giving his joints as much of a break as possible.

“I think things will be fine,” Owen said, breaking into the conversation at last. “It’s only a half-hour panel. We’ll take a few questions, snap a few photos, and maybe at the end a couple of Supers will leave here ready to apply to be PEERS. Galvanize is right. This is a charity event. No one is going to make a scene.” Owen wasn’t entirely sure he believed that; there were those who still had extreme opinions about the Hero known as Titan. Either way, he was sure his team would be fine, though. If security couldn’t handle a problem, then Titan would.

“Anyway, that’s not until this afternoon,” Galvanize reminded them. “For the morning, we’ve still all got our own work to do, which means we should get moving. Remember: on time is ten minutes late.”

This phrase was met with muttered grumblings from the rest of his team, Owen included, as they spread out and left the parking lot. The others were no doubt going to work booths for Mordent again, toiling their days

away until the inevitable panel. Owen, however, was off to something slightly different.

When signing up for his activities all those weeks ago, one particular option had caught his eye. A booth had been set aside for recruiters, sometimes ones that were Heroes, to talk with potential applicants about Sizemore Tech's Hero Certification Program, and try to convince those with the right skills to try and apply. It was something he'd done many years before and in truth would have enjoyed doing again. Just jumping in didn't seem right, given how his reputation had changed, though. Instead, he'd reached out to the booth's organizer and set up a meeting. If it went well, he might pitch in. If not. . . well, Owen hadn't ever really expected to be able to go back into that world anyway.

Despite the early hour, there were already at least a half-dozen high school kids clustered around the front of the tent. They whispered as he passed by, a sound Owen was quickly growing accustomed to, but didn't seem terribly shocked to see him walking around. By now, word had doubtlessly spread that Titan was on the premises. Moving past them, he walked all the way around to the back, where a white tent was set up. Later in the day, this would be the air-conditioned break area for the recruiters to lounge in between talking to prospective students. Currently, however, there was only a single occupant inside as Owen pulled back the flap.

"Titan, good to see you back in a mask." The man who was standing there was tall, nearly comparable to Owen himself, with wide shoulders and muscular arms. This was especially impressive since a head of white hair and noticeable wrinkles betrayed his advanced age. With one large step he closed the gap between them and took Owen's hand in a firm shake.

"Dean Jackson, it's always a pleasure." Owen shook the hand right back, then took a seat on a couch clearly made for the outdoors and settled in for his meeting with the dean of Sizemore Tech's Hero Certification Program.

“So. . . you’re back in.”

Dean Jackson sat across from Owen with the same careful, measured expression he’d worn back before the name Titan was more than some boring old piece of Greek mythology. Of course, that had been decades ago, when Dean Jackson still had his dark hair and Owen was comparatively scrawny. Idly, Owen found himself wondering how many years the old warhorse had left in him. It was hard to imagine anyone running Sizemore Tech aside from Herbert Jackson. It always seemed like he’d been there since the first brick was laid and would continue running it until it was rubble.

“I’m back in,” Owen confirmed. “For a while now. Working as a Hero Liaison for a team of PEERS.”

Dean Jackson nodded, the wrinkles around his forehead bunching together as a thoughtful expression found its way to his face. “A fine job, working with good people. I’ve always felt the PEERS get shortchanged; they do as much as good as we do, and without having to get blood on their hands.”

“I can’t say I always agreed, but being with this team has made me realize how vital they are.” Owen was a bit surprised to hear Dean Jackson be so positive about PEERS. He could scarcely remember the man saying anything kind about anyone, save for the mightiest of Heroes that had come before. Then again, it had been a long time since they last talked. Perhaps time had tempered his perspective just as it had Owen’s.

“To be frank, I was a little surprised to hear from you.” Now that the basic pleasantries were over, Dean Jackson was clearly moving things to the heart of the matter. He was a busy man with a lot on his mind, and as such he rarely bothered to beat around any bushes. It was one of the qualities Owen admired most in his former dean. “Getting back into the Hero world is one thing, and make no mistake, I’m sleeping sounder knowing that you’re out there, but doing recruiting work is a bit stickier.”

“The name Titan tends to earn some polarizing reactions,” Owen agreed. “And I understand completely if you don’t want me coming around the Sizemore booth. I just wanted to offer, in case it was something you decided would be beneficial. You know I love my alma mater.”

“Yet you sent your sons to Lander,” Dean Jackson replied.

Owen wasn’t exactly shocked that an HCP dean would be in the know about that, though he was taken slightly aback. Before he had a chance to defend himself, Dean Jackson continued, this time with what Owen thought might be a slight chuckle in his tone.

“Relax, I understand why it was the best fit considering their. . . situation. My ego has long ago made peace with the fact that Dean Blaine is far more capable at neutralizing a Super than I am. Were they my students and things went awry, there’s no certainty that I could stop them without making it permanent.”

“Thankfully, so far things have gone fine.” Owen wasn’t entirely sure how much Dean Jackson knew, so it seemed prudent to keep things as vague as possible.

“Better than fine; that class they’re in seems to be quite the strong one, yet they’re hanging in. It’s bad enough that all anyone can talk about for this year’s upcoming Intramurals is the golden girl from Lander and unstoppable boy from West. Damn thing is still months away and it’s like we other three schools are just already assumed to have lost. If I have to put up with another year of it, I might end up popping the other deans in their mouths.”

Dean Jackson leaned back slowly in his white plastic folding chair, the worn cushion underneath likely providing little to no comfort whatsoever.

“I’ll level with you: Sizemore could use a little help reminding people that we produce just as amazing of Heroes as everyone else. With Globe busting Relentless Steel out of prison last year, all people are talking about is the damn Class of Legends again. I’d love to rub one of our own legends in their faces. If you’re willing to do a little work here and there, I think we can at least draw in the students who look up to you for the top-tier ass-kicker you are.”

“And what about the people who steer clear because they hate me?” Owen pointed out.

“Fuck ‘em.” Dean Jackson rested his hands against each other, fingertips pressing on their counterparts. It was a position Owen had rarely seen his dean in when he was a student, but since graduation had come to learn as a signal that the older man was making a firm decision. “I’m not training the kind of milquetoast Heroes that would pass up a good education because an alumnus happened to make a mistake, and I’m damn sure not



going to teach someone who believes your orientation affects how good a Hero you are. Even if no one thinks my HCP trains the strongest Heroes right now, I can still make sure I churn out ones that deserve to wear the title.”

Owen certainly couldn’t argue with that sentiment, especially since he’d seen it in action first hand. Dean Jackson had tossed out more than a couple of students who might have had the potential for greatness simply because they failed to live up to his standards of character. Sizemore Tech might not have as many Heroes who were household names as some of the other schools, but they also had the lowest number of Heroes turn criminal by a wide margin.

“Well, Dean Jackson, you let me know what I can do to help and I’ll be glad to pitch in. Sizemore gave a lot to me, I’m happy to give back to it.”

“Don’t suppose you could re-enroll in time for Intramurals, could you? Now *that* would be an upset worth watching.” Dean Jackson chuckled to himself, then shook his head. “Never mind, never mind. We’ll just get them next year. For now, if you’re willing to stop by the booth during operating hours, maybe help out a recruiter with the more obstinate potential students, I think that will be fine. Likely more work will come down the line, but for now starting small seems best. Besides, according to the schedule you’ve got a panel to be at this afternoon.”

“I’m all too aware,” Owen said, sighing heavily. “Why can’t every aspect of Hero work just be punching? That’s the part I’m good at.”

“No argument here.” Dean Jackson pulled himself out of the chair with a single motion, no sign of his age present in the way he moved. “But until the world devolves into a dystopian wasteland with nothing but constant combat, our kind will have to soldier on. Want to get some breakfast?”

As it turned out, Owen very much did want breakfast, or at least a breakfast that wasn’t carefully calorically calculated. There was no amount of skillful cooking that could replace good old-fashioned grease and salt.

For all the worry he'd had about standing in front of people while publicly representing Sizemore Tech, Owen's morning was shockingly uneventful. He sat around with the recruiter, a nice young man who was paid by the DVA to help potential students understand what the HCP entailed, and occasionally answered a question from a nervous teen.

While Titan might have been a household name a couple of decades ago, the vast majority of the kids he talked to had only a cursory knowledge at best of who he was. Even if he'd been in his prime, though, Owen had forgotten that most teenagers, especially Supers interested in the HCP, were far too nervous about their own future to worry about much else. Owen spent the vast majority of his time at the booth discussing whether or not some particular power could make it in the HCP, since that was the first question out of nearly every potential applicant's mouth.

To nearly all of them, Owen gave the same answer: for admission, the power was less important than the person. These Supers would find their limits in the HCP, and at that time they would learn if it was enough to let them make the cut. Just in terms of making it through the admissions process, however, one's power was almost secondary. Determination, willpower, strength of character, and guts all counted just as much, if not more, than what ability a student was born with. True, those who failed to improve or keep up would quickly be culled in the freshman year, but everyone who applied with at least a decent power had a shot. Save, of course, for those with completely useless abilities and Poweredreds.

Poweredreds were heavy on Owen's mind as he finished his time at the booth and began the trek across the fairgrounds. He'd left plenty of time to reach the pavilion before Galvanize's deadline, so he paused to swing by a tent that was sponsored by Shelby's House, the largest charity for Poweredreds in the nation. The small staff was trying to coax passers-by in to donating their time at any of the local chapters in Brewster. Every one of the workers was young, and a few were charming enough that they'd actually gotten people to stop. Still, it was a losing battle, as it had always been. No one liked to think too much about Poweredreds: what they were, what they represented, or the problems they caused.

Owen had never taken his sons to a chapter of Shelby's House; being a

Hero meant he could have experts assess their condition. Being a famous Hero also meant he had the spare income to take care of them, and to make sure they had the chance to come to peace with their abilities. Titan, on the other hand, had spent a large chunk of his time at chapters of Shelby's House across the nation. He'd given as much time as he could spare to the organization that only luck and career choice had spared him from needing. Of course, knowing what he did about Hershel and Roy, Owen was keyed in to the fact that in the next decade or so, Powereds might become a thing of the past.

"Excuse me; I'd like to sign up to volunteer."

The copper-haired woman stared up at him, visibly craning her neck to take in the giant of a man standing before her. Unlike the teenagers, she definitely recognized him, and the nervous shifting of her eyes made it clear that she wasn't sure what to do with the offer. Heroes usually went through different channels, they didn't sign up with workers on at a booth.

"You. . . know what we do here, right?"

Owen smiled and gave her a large nod. "I very much do. And I'd like to help." Carefully, Owen took the pen and clipboard from her hand and scratched the name "Titan" along with his contact information. It was a message service that Heroes used, one that would see to it he got any actual calls or e-mail and kept out the waves of spam or harassment.

"I'm not trying to do PR work or anything. I can sweep floors if you need it. Whatever helps." Owen handed the young woman back the clipboard, which she accepted limply with her mouth still half-open. Without another word, he turned and started toward the pavilion once again.

Behind him, Owen could already hear the crowd forming around the workers, people who'd been ignoring their calls suddenly desperate to find out what was happening with the volunteers of Shelby's House. If he was lucky, word would spread, and they'd spend the day getting the attention that was really due to their cause. That clipboard would be filled with people wanting to chip in within the hour, that much was a given. It wasn't a lot, in the grand scheme of things, but it was what he could do for now. After all, a cure in ten years wasn't much help to the Powereds just trying to make it through the week.

The rest of the trip to the pavilion was uneventful, assuming one didn't count the usual array of stares and whispers that cropped up as he

walked through the fairgrounds. Owen walked past a security guard manning the back entrance, pausing to give the man a handshake, and made his way up a narrow set of stairs. Though, in fairness, the stairs wouldn't have been narrow for anyone else, but that was the curse of carrying around so much mass.

"And there he is!" Hexcellent said, sitting in a small makeup chair. The other three were seated alongside her, being touched up by the staff Mordent had hired to ensure they looked their best. It was, after all, a public appearance, and they were the faces of several Mordent brands. One of the men holding a handful of brushes looked at Owen, who simply pointed to his mask. No need to work on what nobody could see.

"Am I late or something?" Owen made his way over to the side of the room and sat down carefully on a large box, which thankfully held his weight.

"Since you didn't need to be checked over, you're right on time," Galvanize assured him. "Mr. Greene requested the rest of us come a bit earlier than we'd planned to make certain we were the best representation of the company that we could be."

"Personally, I think he just got wind of how many people were coming to this thing and decided to doll us up," Bubble Bubble added, tilting her head back as a staff member applied her eyeliner.

"This might not be that big of a house, but damn if we didn't pack the fucker," Hexcellent announced. "Standing room only."

Owen got up from his box and went over to the edge of the room, which adjoined an outdoor stage in front of a small cluster of benches. Sure enough, there were dozens of people out there, though mercifully almost none in costume, along with beefy security guards walking around to keep order. Deep down, he'd known this was a possibility, but seeing so many faces before him, Owen couldn't help the tickle of nerves in his gut. This time, there would be no other Heroes to protect him if the crowd tried to turn things south.

No, this time he was the one who had to do the protecting. Whatever the world may think of him, his team deserved to be treated with respect. And Owen was damned determined to make sure that happened.

“Got the jitters?” Hexcellent had sidled up to Owen, her goth makeup now done perfectly as she eyed the stage. “It’s okay if you do. It just means you’re a cowardly pussy. That’s all.”

“You know I used to do public appearances multiple times a day, right?” Owen said.

“And I used to shit my bed when I was a baby. Doesn’t mean I’d feel comfortable doing it tonight,” Hexcellent shot back.

“Everyone, it’s time.” Galvanize’s announcement came from behind them, so Owen and Hexcellent both stepped aside. After all, it was only right that their team leader go first.

He walked briskly past them, the usual charming smile affixed firmly in place, and then Hexcellent fell in behind him. Next was Zone and after that Bubble Bubble. Finally, at the end of the procession, was Owen, who stepped out into the public eye for the second time in two days.

The open roof allowed the afternoon sun to pour in, keeping everything on the stage just a touch too warm. Oddly, he felt more at ease as soon as the stares and sunlight hit him. Any actual conflict, be it a fight or a crowd of possible assholes, was never as scary for him as the anticipation. Once the action kicked off, there was no room in Owen for fear. He was usually too busy trying to keep everyone alive.

The others quickly sat in their chairs, leaving Owen the one at the end of the table again. He noted that this seat was extra-large and reinforced, just like the chair he’d sat in yesterday. In fact, there seemed like a very real possibility that it was the exact same seat. Idly, he wondered if some poor staff member was dragging it from event to event for him. Then Owen realized he’d been standing, staring at his chair for a hair too long, so he quickly threw himself into it. The reinforcement turned out to be a good idea, as audible creaks could be heard when Owen settled in.

“Good afternoon, everyone.” Galvanize was talking into the small microphone set up before him, his voice completely calm, as if a near-giant hadn’t just stared at a chair then collapsed on it so quickly he nearly turned it to debris. “My name is Galvanize, and with me here is the rest of my PEERS

team: Hexcellent, Zone, Bubble Bubble, and our Hero Liaison, Titan. We've come here today to answer any questions you might have about what it takes to be PEERS, or a Hero Liaison, if any of you are interested in working in that capacity. I understand the staffers took your questions ahead of time, so please ask them as you're brought a microphone."

Pre-vetting the questions: smart. It was easy to think of his team as just kids, but Owen tried to remind himself that they were media savvy performers who'd been doing this for years without him. None of them showed the slightest amount of worry as the event staff member made his way through the crowd to a muscular man in a tank top. They all seemed completely self-assured, despite the nearly endless complaining about doing the event. Owen, it seemed, wasn't the only one who knew how to put on his game face.

"Yeah, I was wondering, if I got rejected by the HCP, does that mean I'm not qualified to do the rescue stuff either?" Owen couldn't quite place the man's accent, though he did note the way his eyes flicked to Titan's side of the table when he talked about the HCP. It was a fair question, though; getting denied to go into the Hero business was a hard moment for a lot of Supers to swallow, and many didn't want to open themselves up to that sort of rejection again.

"If you all don't mind, I'd love to take this one," Galvanize said, looking up and down the table. When no one objected, he looked back at the man in the tank top and continued. "That is absolutely, one thousand percent not the case. The Hero Certification Program is a great system full of wonderful people, but what they're looking for is a narrow view compared to all the different kinds of Supers out there. Just because you weren't a good fit for them doesn't mean your power can't help someone. That's why I wanted to take this question; I was turned down by every HCP three years in a row when I was younger. It wasn't out of malice; it was simply because neither I nor my power had what they were looking for. Fast forward a few years, and I've been able to do a lot of good on PEERS teams, so much so that they let me run one of my own."

Polite applause filled the room and their first question asker took a seat. The microphone was passed down several rows down to a short girl with mousy brown hair. She reached out slowly, as if she were afraid the staff member was going to smack her with the microphone, before finally starting to speak.

“Hi. Um, my name is Hillary, and I was just wondering if you have to be really outgoing to do this kind of work. My power is solid, but I’m not so good at talking in front of people.” Given that she was half-whispering in the microphone, the part about her shyness was already evident. Before she’d really finished getting her question out, Hexcellent was leaning forward and gripping her own microphone like it owed her money.

“Yeah, I got this one.” She shot some glares up and down the table, lest anyone dare to object, which no one did. Even Owen, the newest member of the team, knew not to try and stand in the way when Hexcellent got her mind set on something.

“Look, Hillary you said it was, here’s the thing no one explained to me until I’d gotten been stuffed into a pink costume and had my fucking roots dyed blonde: there’s a brand to fit every personality type out there, and a good company will find it for you. When I came to work for Mordent, one of the first things they did was get a sense of who I was; me, the real person. Upon finding out that I liked heavy metal, dark makeup, and strong language, they paired me with the kind of people who were proud to have that sort of person repping them. If you’ve got what it takes to do the hard work—saving people—then any manager worth their shit will pair you with people that want you to be the shy gal you clearly are and love you for it.”

The applause for Hexcellent was rowdier than it had been for Galvanize, which only seemed fitting given the nature of her reply. As the microphone moved once again, Owen found himself a bit relieved. Despite what everyone on the team had expected, the questions so far were about being PEERS. No one had even mentioned Titan, let alone tried to make the panel about him. Owen wasn’t sure if this was based on the folks who had vetted the questions or if they team had all underestimated genuine interest in the field.

All he knew was that he hoped it held out.

“Yeah, I have a question for Titan.” The young man standing up near the back wore a yellow shirt that was stained with sweat, no doubt a byproduct of standing directly in the sunlight.

Around him, Owen felt his team stiffen slightly. While he’d fielded a few questions that were tossed up so far, this was the first one directed at him. Showing no fear of his own, Owen nodded for the sweaty man to continue.

“I want to know why these teams need Heroes on them at all. All they’re doing is rescuing people, why does a Hero need to get involved?”

“Titan, I can address this one,” Galvanize began, but Owen shook his head.

“No, I think I’ve been on the job long enough to give a good answer.” Owen turned back to the one who’d asked the question. “The simple truth of it is that they don’t have to have a Hero Liaison if they don’t want to. Instead, a PEERS team is welcome to pair up with local law enforcement agencies. They can rent space in the police station and act as a support unit for rescues and emergency services. But I think you were probably asking why they need supervision at all, not necessarily just from Heroes, am I right?”

“Yeah.” It was more grunt than word, but Owen accepted it.

“That’s because as dedicated and powerful as any given PEERS team is, they aren’t trained for engaging with Supers who are hostile.” Owen leaned slightly back, taking his microphone with him, and allowed his eyes to scan the crowd. “It’s an unfortunate but real truth that in many of the cases where emergency services are needed, Supers or Powereds are involved. Sometimes it’s unintentional, an incident involving a young kid still learning to deal with their abilities. Other times it’s less innocent. I’m not saying every fire or busted building is the result of our kind, mind you, only that the risk is constantly present. That’s why we pair teams of PEERS with Heroes or law enforcement: to make sure they’re properly protected should such a situation arise.”

A light applause swept through the crowd, nothing like Hexcellent had managed to garner during her answers, but enough to signify they liked his reply. The staff member with the microphone tried to move on to the next



guest; however, the man in the yellow shirt kept hold of it, clearly not happy with the answer he'd received.

"That's bullshit and you know it. This is just another way for so-called 'Heroes' to get more influence and control over the lives of real human-" The remainder of his rant was cut off as a burly staff member physically separated the yellow-shirted man from the microphone. Already, two others working security were heading over, no doubt to toss him from the pavilion, if not the fairgrounds as a whole.

Owen tried to think of something to settle the crowd, who were visibly unnerved by the unexpected verbal attack, but he wasn't nearly as quick-witted as another member of his team, who grabbed hold of her own mic and addressed the crowd.

"Whoa there, asshole, I'm not exactly a big fan of Heroes either, but that doesn't change the fact that we see some dangerous shit out there." The security guards, troublemaker firmly in hand, slowed down slightly to let Hexcellent say her piece. "Titan here has kept us safe from fires, collapsing bridges, and even a bunch of dickhead gang members. Before him, Mirror Fog made sure we never went into situations too dangerous to handle. There are a lot of Heroes out there with god complexes and enough ego to choke a donkey, but the ones who come aboard to help us usually aren't in that lot. And even if some are, Titan damn sure isn't among them."

Hexcellent, ever the crowd favorite, was treated to enthusiastic applause. Owen was a bit taken aback at how quick she'd been, not only getting things back on track but turning what had actually been an attack on Heroes in general into something personal she could defend. If this was what she was like when she actually tried, it was no wonder Mordent let her get away with so much. Hexcellent could deliver when the chips were down and she felt the need.

"Oh, and as for that 'real human' talk you started to spout, I've been around enough to know Purist bullshit when I hear it. Security, throw him out of here. Something tells me he's got a cow to fuck and a cross-burning to start."

The crowd cheered loudly, while across the table Galvanize stuck his head in his hands. Regardless of the amount of leash Hexcellent had, that part might have been a bit over the line in terms of what Mordent would forgive, especially given how many people were recording the panel. If Hexcellent noticed or cared, she didn't show it; instead she threw her arms in the air and

encouraged the crowd to get even louder.

For his part, Owen kept an eye on the man they were escorting out of the pavilion. Human-Purists might be the largest and best organized of Super hate groups, but they were far from the most radical. Usually they limited themselves to picketing outside events featuring Heroes, spreading the message that people with powers weren't true humans, and of course trying to pass legislation to strip Supers and Powered's of their basic rights. That was as a group, though; the actions of an individual could never be completely predicted, which was why Owen didn't completely relax until the aggressor was completely out of sight. Given how many celebrity athletes and Heroes were present, security had been top-notch, but Owen had seen too many sure things go sideways to ever trust precautions completely.

"All right, now that the dickhead is gone, let's move on to a fun question. Clipboard guy, pick us a good one," Hexcellent demanded.

The staff member, caught off guard by the request, quickly skimmed through the list of remaining questions and selected one, hurrying over to a woman in a blue cap. She jumped up from her seat and took the mic, grinning from ear-to-ear.

"Aside from Bubble Bubble and that fuckwad director, I wanted to ask: who else among you has gotten to bang a celebrity?"

Around her the crowd began to hoot, and Hexcellent's laughter could be heard ringing through the speakers as she immediately turned to Zone and began trying to extract stories from him. Galvanize did his best to reassert control, but it was a largely futile effort.

The crowd had chosen their own leader, and it was a woman decked out in goth makeup.

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“The old ghost of the battlefield let you do a little recruiting, huh? Good for him, I always liked that curmudgeon.”

Lenny poured the cold beer from his fridge into two chilled pint glasses while Owen waited in the living room. As a rule, Lenny made it a point to check in with his clients regularly, and this whole charity event had provided a rare moment of predictability in Titan’s schedule. Thus, with the panels done for the day, the agent and Hero were having a sit-down to address any problems or opportunities that might have arisen. Lenny found the more often he did this, the less frequently he had drunken people banging on his door at two in the morning.

When Lenny turned around, beers in hand, he found Owen staring at him with an unexpected look of amusement. “You aren’t supposed to know that’s his nickname. Technically, you’re not even supposed to know what his power is or Hero name was.”

“Just try doing recruiting in all these schools and not picking up a little information here and there.” Lenny walked over, cold beers in hand, and set them down on coasters that were resting on his coffee table. “No one ever worries about an agent betraying HCP secrets. For one thing, we make our livelihood off our talent for discretion, and for another, just getting in the doors of those places means I’ve signed so many nondisclosures that the government could hurl me into a windowless cell for the rest of my life. Which I am not game for; you think they carry my damn orthopedic insoles in prison? Hell no.”

“We’ve got people who can melt buildings with a glance or punch through skulls like tissue, and that’s the thing that scares you.” Owen snickered as he reached for his beer, taking a tentative taste. It was good, but not great. Interesting. Lenny saved the great stuff for when he had bad news to take the edge off. Things must be looking up.

“What can I say, you get to my age and the body becomes a lemon in need of constant upkeep.” Lenny looked up and down at the giant muscle-bound man who refused to show more than cursory aging. “Okay, maybe not when *you* get to my age. . .”

They shared a laugh at this and sank into light conversation as they

worked through their beers. Both knew business would come later, but Lenny enjoyed reinforcing the personal relationship with his clients when the opportunity arose. It helped them to trust him when things got rough and they needed careful steering, plus it made them less likely to jump ship for some schmutz offering false promises and a lower percentage.

Eventually, however, the chitchat came to an end as Lenny set down his half-drunk beer and looked Owen in the eye.

“I think it’s time we got down to brass tacks. Namely, how you want to start moving from here.”

Owen looked at his agent uncertainly, motioning for the small man to go on.

“I’m saying you need to make a plan, chart a path, start figuring out where you want to go. The public is responding well to you, and your stock is once again on the rise. Hell, didn’t you wonder why Dean Jackson was so willing to let you wave the Sizemore flag? After the fight with Elemental Fury, people are starting to remember why the name Titan was a household one even before the scandal.”

“It’s been nice, sure, but I’m not certain what you’re getting at here,” Owen replied, nursing the remainder of his drink.

“I’m getting at the fact that you’re beginning to have options. Hero teams have started sniffing around, seeing how mobile you’re willing to be. Now I’m not saying you need to jump right now; there’s still a lot of groundwork to be laid. But if you’ve got some top picks we can work in that direction and make you as appealing as possible.”

“But. . . I already have a team.”

Lenny stared at Owen for a long while, leaning back against his couch and taking his drink with him. “Yes, you do. A team of corpies that you didn’t want to join in the first place. Maybe we’re not on the same page here, Titan. I thought this would be a stepping stone to get you back out there. You get to rehab your reputation a bit, and a PEERS team gets training and protection from a world-class Hero. The long-term hope was that you’d eventually outgrow it and move on to a place where you could do more good.”

“I guess. . . I suppose that might have been in the back of my head when I first started this. But now, they’re my team. I don’t know that I’d feel right abandoning them,” Owen said.

“Who’s asking you to abandon anyone? There would be a transition time where you trained their new Hero Liaison, a job that plenty of people are interested in doing since you elevated their status. You could see them socially as well, if you wanted. Heroes change teams for various reasons all the time, you know that.”

With one swallow, Owen finished off the last of his beer and set down the glass. “Maybe so, but this isn’t a Hero team. It’s a PEERS one. I like being there, I like watching over them, and I like that a big chunk of my time gets dedicated to rescue work instead of having to get my hands bloody.”

“Look, Titan, this is your life, your career, your second chance,” Lenny said, his tone gentle as he scooted forward on the couch cushion. “You want to stay with the PEERS? That’s completely fine by me. I only brought this up because when you came to me, you said you wanted back in the life because you felt like you could take on the hard jobs, the ones that might get other people killed. As your agent, I took that to heart and have been trying to get you into a position where you can best fill that role. Which, we can both agree, is on a team of Heroes, who spend nearly all their time on the clock. Maybe I misunderstood what the end goal was; maybe things changed along the way. Point is, if we need to change directions, you just give me the new coordinates.”

“No, you’re right. That’s what I came back for.” Owen looked down at his hands, wide and strong, and thought back to how many times he’d used them to take another person’s life. People that could have, would have, killed other Heroes who didn’t have his gifts. Being able to use his power to save without bloodshed, it had been wonderful. A breath of fresh air, a living vacation. But Owen hadn’t come back to take a vacation. He’d come back to do penance, to pay for his time wasted hiding from the world.

“Make some inquiries, I guess. Look around. Like you said, we’re a long way off from having to actually take any real steps forward.”

“I’ll be completely discreet,” Lenny assured him. “And no promises will be made until you’re ready. Take your time, enjoy being with those kids. You do deserve to be happy sometimes, you know.”

Owen nodded, not sure if he really believed the words but appreciating them anyway. “Thanks, Lenny. How about another beer?”

Owen could hear the familiar beeping of electronic battle before he stepped through the front door of the Mordent penthouse. Hexcellent, no doubt, playing her games and cursing at the screen. Bubble Bubble would probably be nearby, reading a magazine or surfing the internet. Zone would be in the gym, either exercising or icing his knees. And Galvanize, the team leader, would probably be off somewhere doing all the work that kept things running smooth. It had snuck up on him, how much he'd gotten to know and care about these people, barely older than his own children, in their time together. It had never really struck him that there might be an end in sight; now that it had, he entered the room with a heart that was just a touch heavier than normal.

To his surprise, it was not only Hexcellent smashing on the control as her digital avatar battled a giant woman with a fearsome axe. Bubble Bubble was sitting next to her, controlling said axe-wielder, focusing so hard on the fight that she'd forgotten to wear her usual mask of composure. Nearby, Galvanize sat on the couch, eating some of the butter-and-salt-free popcorn that they kept on hand. Zone was in the corner, doing some light curls as he watched the scene unfold.

"Must be one hell of a game," Owen said, taking in the scene before him.

"Round-robin tournament," Hexcellent spat out, physically jerking her whole body as she angled her ninja with a giant spear around the screen, leaping down to score a hit on Bubble Bubble that took off nearly a quarter of her health.

"Since we had a long day today, and have to do the tug-of-war tomorrow, it seemed like a good idea for us all to unwind," Galvanize said, shrugging as if he'd been bullied along into agreeing.

"Hexcellent and I are in the lead," Zone boasted. "So far we've done racing games and fighting games."

"Those reflexes of yours aren't going to mean shit once we get to the puzzle games," Hexcellent said, slamming her fists into the buttons so hard Owen genuinely feared for the plastic device's safety. "You can still jump in, if you want. Obviously you can't win, but I've seen you play. I think we all

know that was never going to happen in the first place.”

“Cruel, but accurate,” Owen admitted. Part of him wanted to retire to his room, to think about what Lenny had said and what the future held. But that was just dwelling, and if the bar in Colorado had proved nothing else, it was that once Owen started dwelling, it took a hell of a lot to shake him out of it. His time was better spent around the people he enjoyed. “Let me grab a shower first, then I’ll come out here and snatch last place away from whoever currently has the title.”

“That would be Galvanize,” Bubble Bubble supplied helpfully.

“My parents thought video games would rot the mind,” Galvanize said, mounting a weak defense to his apparent lack of digital skills.

“Who the hell wants an unrotted mind?” Hexcellent asked as she made her ninja throw the spear, which slammed just below the axe-wielding woman’s sternum and took away the remainder of her hit points. “Booyah! Suck my metaphorical dick.”

“There are days I wonder about the metaphorical part,” Bubble Bubble muttered. “Galvanize, you’re up. Hurry before Titan finishes his shower so fewer of us will see your shame.”

As Galvanize headed for her seat on the couch, Owen made his way down the hall toward his room. Happy as it made him, it was strange to see them all together like this. He was so sure they’d be off doing their own thing when he got back; how could he have been so wrong? It was just as Owen’s hand closed around the doorknob of his room that the answer struck him.

Owen had been predicting their actions based on how they used to be. Between waves of criminals under collapsing bridges, watching their liaison take on a whole team of Heroes, Bubble Bubble’s own scandal, and occasionally sneaking beers, they’d actually started to come together. Not only as a team, but as a unit of people who liked one another. It was strangely heartwarming to realize he’d gotten to bear witness to such an event and maybe, in his own small ways, helped contribute to it.

His fingers were just reaching under his mask, preparing to peel it away, when a familiar voice appeared in his right ear. “Titan, this is Dispatch. Are you on-comm?”

“Titan responding; what’s going on, Dispatch?” He lowered his hands from the mask, letting it rest in place. Depending on Dispatch’s next words,

he might need to go right back out into the world, and still being in costume would save him several precious seconds. They wouldn't mean much to him, but for anyone who needed help, those seconds might be a literal lifesaver.

“Modus Operandi has requested a bulletin go out to all Heroes in the Brewster area. Today, several covert attacks were carried out on the communications network in and around all of Brewster. While they did not interrupt phone and internet services, they did cripple them. The restraint was estimated to be intentional. It is expected that one more set of attacks will bring down the entire communication structure, though our own Hero-issue equipment would not be affected, thanks to the alternate systems used.”

“Got it. Someone sawed through most of the tree that is Brewster's communications network, so that they can bring the whole thing down with one good blow when they need to. Add a little mayhem, and with no one able to talk to one another it's a recipe for chaos. Damn, that is crafty,” Owen admitted. “So what's the plan for fixing it? Since Modus Operandi noticed the attacks, I'm guessing they've got a way to patch things back up. Do they need me to lift anything?”

“I will check, though it is doubtful.” Dispatch either had no sense of humor or willfully plowed through jokes, which seemed like the same thing after long enough working with her. “Modus Operandi asked me to pass on this bulletin in order to request that no Hero take any action to repair the damage. They feel at this point showing our awareness would make the attackers wary, perhaps changing their plans. To quote: ‘Next time we might not catch their ambush ahead of time.’ Therefore, all Heroes are placed on alert to a potential situation in the next week and asked to keep their earpieces in at all times.”

“I'll do that,” Owen said, beginning once more to pull his mask away. “And Dispatch, would you be so kind as to pass a message to Jeremiah of Modus Operandi back for me?”

“Certainly, Titan. What is your message?”

“Tell him I understand the tactical need for taking this kind of risk, and I get where they're coming from with wanting to capitalize on advanced knowledge.” Owen flung his mask onto his bed, where it lay there, staring up at him.

“All the same, I'm not a fan of using a whole fucking city for bait. Tell Jeremiah that he'd better be ready for whatever comes, because if this goes



sideways, I'm holding him personally responsible."

"Your message will be passed on," Dispatch replied. "Though it may be a while before he hears it. There are currently twenty other similarly worded messages ahead of yours in his queue."

Owen snickered, and considered the possibility that Dispatch might just have a sense of humor in there after all.

Despite Jeremiah's cryptic warning, the third day of the charity event started off just like all the others. True, Owen might have been a bit more on guard as he wandered about the booths doing some meet-and-greets, signings, and shaking hands. And he might have readied himself just a touch too quickly every time a loud noise met his ears, as if he expected chaos to break out at any moment. As the day wore on, however, Owen gradually let his nerves settle, reminding himself that technically trouble was always around the potential bend. All stressing over it would do was wear him down for when he was actually needed.

By the time the day's main event rolled around, Owen had managed to completely settle, a feeling that lasted only until he arrived at the stadium. It was a run-down relic of times long past, back when Brewster was a small city with little more than a farm league in the realm of professional sports. Across town there was a new, high-tech stadium where actual events were hosted, yet the original field was still here on the fairgrounds, steadfastly refusing to crumble or give way in spite of its age and wear. Owen felt a kinship to the battered building as soon as he set foot on the green, well cared-for turf.

Already several of the teams, the vast majority of them players from the SAA, were out warming up for the tug-of-war. Some were having matches against teammates, others were tossing a ball around, and a few were just slowly curling weights while making conversation. It was a festive atmosphere; everyone seemed in high spirits about the impending event.

For a moment, Owen was taken aback by the jovial ambiance. Years of Hero work had conditioned him to equate using his powers in public with danger, towards others and occasionally himself. But that wasn't the case today. No one was going to get hurt, unless they turned an ankle or something. Hell, it didn't even matter who won. Aside from bragging rights, the only real prize today was selling the tickets and raising money for charity. Which, if the crowd lined up outside was any indication, they'd already accomplished.

Scanning the field, Owen finally saw his own team, grouped up near Galvanize as he no doubt drilled them on proper rope-pulling techniques. Owen was halfway to them when a familiar voice flagged him down.

“Titan! Hey, wait up.”

From across the field, Kaiju jogged over. Though the young man was still in his human form, Owen had seen how quickly that could change. He glanced over to where Kaiju was coming from, noting that Juiced and Deadlift were both chalking their hands and practicing grips. This competition might be more interesting than he’d expected; Deadlift’s power alone was bound to have some unexpected effects.

“Afternoon, Kaiju,” Owen said as the Hero finally came to a stop several feet away. Around them, a few people looked over, noticing for the first time that Titan had arrived.

“Afternoon yourself,” Kaiju replied. “I’d heard people saying you were going to be part of this, but I didn’t really believe it. Are you actually going to come tug a rope around with us low-end schmucks?”

While the assessment might have been harsh, it was true that there were very few other Heroes on the field, and of those that were present, Owen recognized almost none. These sorts of events usually weren’t appealing to Heroes from a PR perspective. If you were popular and won, pretty much nothing changed, but if you were popular and lost, people might think less of you. It was a poor bet for most Heroes to make, the obvious exception being ones that needed exposure and had little image to lose, such as a disgraced team that had barely held on to their certifications, for example.

“What can I say, I heard you all were going to be here and couldn’t pass up that challenge. Who knows when I’ll get another opportunity to actually test myself against that kind of power,” Owen replied.

Kaiju smiled, a small, guarded one that clearly said he knew Owen was just being polite, but it was still a smile all the same. “Whatever you say, big man. Well, it doesn’t change much for us; we were already expected to lose early. This is just one more check in the column against us.”

Owen let out a snort that was so loud it startled a nearby man doing push-ups. “Who the hell would expect you three to lose? You’re a team of strongmen—and women—plus Deadlift’s ability is bound to make things interesting.”

“Sure, we’ve got power, but what we don’t have are alternates,” Kaiju said. “Every match is teams of three, and while the others have people to change out so they can rest, we’re going to have to do each one by ourselves. Since we’re going against other strongmen, it’s bound to get tiring.”

“Maybe so, but I’ve seen you three fight. Something tells me you’re not going to let a little thing like fatigue slow you down.” Owen started to say more, but a loud female voice echoed through the ancient stadium, crackling across the speakers with a healthy amount of feedback.

“Attention: all competitors for the tug-of-war please report to your starting areas. The gates will be opened to spectators in five minutes. Again, please report to your starting areas; guests will begin arriving in five minutes.”

“Did she sound familiar to you?” Owen asked.

Kaiju shook his head. “Doesn’t ring a bell. Then again, over all that static, I doubt I’d even recognize Juiced’s voice, and she is not shy about filling the base with it when someone eats her waffles.”

“Must be my imagination.” Owen looked at Juiced and Deadlift, who’d put down their rope and seemed to be stretching. “Good luck to you all. I’m not sure how the bracket system on this thing works, but if we face each other, I hope it’s in the final match.”

“Same here. Though ideally someone else will take you out, and we’ll capitalize on some fatal flaw in their team dynamic,” Kaiju replied. “But yes, barring that, here’s hoping we meet you in the finals.”

He turned and jogged back toward his team, and Owen headed toward Galvanize and the others. Already he could hear the excited chatter of the large crowd coming from outside the gates. In minutes, they’d come pouring through.

The show was about to begin, and Owen knew he had to be ready. If he was going to leave his team soon, then the least he owed them was a moment in the glorious spotlight of victory.

“Ladies and gentlemen, it is my pleasure to thank you all for coming to today’s main event at the Supers Care Charity Spectacular. We, and more importantly, those in need, greatly appreciate all the funds you’ve helped us raise so far.” The voice crackled through the stadium, audible over the static, but not by much. Thankfully, someone had turned up the volume, as the woman talking now had to compete with a nearly-stuffed stadium. Admittedly, it wasn’t a very large arena, not much bigger than what would be built for a high school football team, but it was still packed full of people eager to witness Supers testing their might against one another.

“Today’s event will be three-person teams in a single elimination tournament, meaning once your team loses, you are out of the running,” the voice continued. “There are white painted lines indicating where to start, and where the midway point is. The first team with a participant to cross that middle line immediately loses, and the winners will move on. Since we’ve got such strong competitors, plus we don’t want to see broken ropes everywhere, the contestants will be using specially fortified ropes. They might weigh upwards of ten times more than the usual kind, but they won’t break easily, and that means you all will really get to see these Supers strut their stuff.”

“I swear I know that voice,” Zone said, peering up at the speaker from next to Owen.

“Yeah, I had the same thought,” Owen agreed.

“Really? Neither of you have placed it yet?” Galvanize had an uncharacteristically smug grin on his face as he looked between his teammates. “Come on, now, I know she didn’t talk much during her player days, but she’s been doing commentary on SAA games for at least five years now.”

“Hooooly shit.” Zone stared up at the speaker with new found respect, and for once he and Owen were on exactly the same page. The secrecy of their revelation was short-lived, as seconds later the voice spoke once more, this time announcing to the crowd what it seemed only Galvanize had figured out.

“And I’ll be down on the field, doing interviews and providing color-commentary throughout the whole event.” From a nearby entrance, a woman

which short brown hair and an athletic build stepped into view. No sooner was she visible than the ever-present roar of the crowd escalated, forcing her to raise her voice. “For those of you who don’t know me, my name is Jade Norris, though they called me The Comet back when I used to-”

The rest of her speech was drowned out by cheering from the stands. While not everyone seemed to know who she was, those who did were clearly overjoyed by the surprise celebrity commentator. She quickly gave up trying to speak over them, instead just waving politely as she waited for the crowd to cheer itself out.

“Damn, is that what it’s like to be A-list?” Hexcellent asked, admiring the crowd’s reaction more than the woman who had triggered it.

“Pretty much,” Owen told her. “Just remember: as loud as they cheer for you, that’s exactly how loud they’ll be when they’re shouting for your blood.”

“Well, that’s a bummer,” Hexcellent muttered.

Owen nodded in agreement. “That’s fame.”

Eventually, the cheers of the crowd faded and Jade was able to get the event underway. The system was well-organized, with three tug-of-war areas set up for the teams to use. Only one match would take place at any given time, but the other spots would minimize any delay in the action. As soon as a team’s match ended, referees would descend on the area, fixing any of the chalk marks that were smudged and dragging the rope back to the starting point. Then the next set of teams would get into position, squared and ready to go as soon as the signal was given. It was a rotation that kept the action constant and the crowd thrilled, never leaving a dull moment in the show.

The team from Mordent Holdings was in the fourth match, set against three players from the Orlando Krakens. Owen recognized two of the three men set on the opposite end of the rope, albeit one was easy, given his distinctive shifted form. The man looked like a cross between a gorilla and a bull. He easily lifted the rope from the ground and handed it to his teammates. While his shifted form wasn’t pretty, it did make him an excellent receiver on the field, and he was no slouch in the muscle department either.

Reaching down carefully, Owen lifted the fortified rope. By human standards, it was probably damn heavy, though in his hand the difference was barely discernible. As the other team hefted their side of the rope, Owen matched their movements and pulled it taut. Logic had dictated he take the

anchor spot at the rear, since that would allow him to make sure there was no slack in the line. It would have been embarrassing for the rest of his teammates to struggle at even lifting the rope they were supposed to pull. This way, at least, they could hold it and appear to be contributing.

Galvanize and Zone got into position, gripping the bundle of woven fiber as tightly as they could. Galvanize was in the front, of course. He was the team leader, and if anyone was going to bear the shame of being pulled across the line, it would be him. In another life, with another power, Owen imagined Galvanize could have been a damn fine leader for a team of Heroes. Then again, he'd found a calling with a team that helped save people, so maybe Galvanize had gotten the right power after all.

Then, with almost no warning, the referee blew the starting whistle and the match began. Owen braced himself as he felt the pressure increase; all three Supers on the other side of the chalk line were pulling with everything they had. The strain increased steadily, taxing Owen's muscles a bit more every second, until finally it leveled out. They'd reached the point where they were pulling with all of their strength, and aside from a few fluctuations of grip and adrenaline, it wasn't going to get any stronger. That was too bad for them, as they were still nowhere near pulling with enough might to actually drag Owen forward, let alone beat him.

With methodical movements, walking backward foot by foot, Owen dragged the other team forward. They struggled, first shocked, then angry, and finally determined as they realized one man was easily beating their combined strength. Digging in with everything they had, the team managed to eke out a bit more power, which was no small feat given how hard they were already working. Sadly, it made no difference as Owen's steady pace continued. Seconds later the first foot was pulled across the chalk line and the referee blew another whistle. The match was over, and the Mordent Holdings team had won.

As Owen lowered the rope and prepared to shake the other team's hands, he noticed something odd. Though the crowd was cheering, Galvanize and Zone were smiling woodenly, their usual charisma absent as they accepted the kind sentiment. Glancing over to where the others were resting, Owen noted that Bubble Bubble and Hexcellent looked much the same. The act was still there, but that's all it was. None of them were happy to be there. If anything, they were embarrassed.

The more Owen considered their situation, the more sense it made.

Everyone knew he was strong. No one was really cheering for them, and they knew it. They were just set-pieces, and much as Mordent tended to prop them up like display models, at least when they did shoots or rescues they were working under their own power, no one liked to feel useless. Especially in such a public venue.

If Owen wanted his team to get any enjoyment or meaning out of the day's activities, he was going to have to think of a new strategy, and soon.



Owen won his team's way through two more matches before an idea finally struck him, and it came from his opponents. In their third match of the day, he was once again up against a hefty shifter and a strongman, but the third member of their team was something a little different. Instead of actually grabbing the rope, he held up his arms and moments later giant energy duplicates of his hands appeared, floating a few feet away. Those massive hands reached down and gingerly picked up the rope as if it weren't even the slightest bit unusual, a wide grin across the projector's face.

"Oooh, and here we see legendary receiver for the Fort Worth Juggernauts, Douglas Fairbanks, using his famous phantom grip," Jade said, hurrying over to be near the action. "For those of you wondering, this is perfectly allowable. The rules state that a Super can use any method at their disposal to move the rope, so long as they move with it and don't interfere with the other team. We thought it would keep things interesting."

She certainly wasn't wrong about that; people's excitement was rekindled as they prepared to watch the strange showdown. Credit where it was due, Owen had to admit this team was probably the strongest they'd faced so far, though it was impossible to tell how much was due to the energy hands. Still, they weren't strong enough, and he dragged the rope backward just as he had all the others before. This time, when he won, the cheers seemed a bit muted. They'd been rooting for the guy with the interesting power, not the one who was slowly plowing through every opponent without putting on a spectacle.

Well, if the crowd wanted to cheer for something unique, they were about to be in a whole mess of luck. Owen headed back over to where the rest of his team was waiting, Zone and Bubble Bubble trailing behind since they'd come out for this match. They were rotating through, not because anyone was getting tired, but because it gave everyone equal time for camera exposure.

Owen motioned for everyone to gather around him, which they did, although there was little enthusiasm in their steps. All wore fake smiles, even Hexcellent, which were obviously as much for his benefit as the cameras. They knew he hadn't chosen to be here and make them suffer through being glorified props; Mordent had forced this upon them, there was no point in throwing blame around on one another.

“Okay, we’ve got a few minutes until the next match,” Owen said, keeping track of how things were going on the field. “Time to figure out who is going in.”

“That’s not really difficult,” Galvanize said. “Zone and I were first, then Bubble Bubble and Hexcellent, followed by Zone and Bubble Bubble, which means it will now be myself and Hexcellent.”

“That’s a good start,” Owen agreed. “But what about your third?”

“Uhhh, that would be you, dipshit,” Hexcellent said, jabbing a finger into his oversized chest.

“Nah, I’ve gone in for the last three matches. I think it’s time to switch things up.” Owen looked his teammates up and down, ignoring the perplexed stares they were shooting him. “Bubble Bubble, I think you should be their third. With your spheres you can create some solid footholds for everyone.”

“Titan,” Galvanize said, lowering his voice as understanding finally sank in. “What are you talking about? You play in every match. You’re the only way we win this thing. That was the plan all along.”

“That was Mordent’s plan, sure,” Owen said. “But we only agreed to show up and compete. No one said I had to be a part of every match. And, come on, do you really want to keep doing more of this shit?”

“Fuck no.” Hexcellent looked surprised by her own words; evidently they’d been meant as inner monologue. Having released them into the world, even if by accident, she steeled herself and opted to own them. “This is embarrassing as hell. We’ve all got our own strengths, but from just watching this contest, you’d think we were fucking useless dickbrains that you carried along everywhere.”

“But we’re winning,” Zone pointed out.

“No, Titan is winning. We’re just there.” Bubble Bubble turned to look up at the crowd, all cheering for the current match and ignoring those on the sidelines. “He’s the only one here they care about.”

“And, if you haven’t noticed, that’s starting to wane,” Owen added. “This isn’t any fun. Not for them, and sure as hell not for us. So I say we change things up and actually try to enjoy ourselves.”

“You realize that we’re going to lose the moment we try to compete.” Despite the pessimistic words, Galvanize actually seemed rather cheerful at

the prospect of public defeat.

“Maybe you will, maybe you won’t. Like Hexcellent said, you’ve got your own strengths. Really though, it doesn’t matter. There’s nothing on the line here but pride, and we might be the team with the least of that to lose. Besides. . .” Owen paused and pointed to the stands and the cheering people within them. “Everyone loves the underdog. Win, lose, it almost doesn’t matter. Just put up a good fight, and the people will clap for you. You might even get some decent publicity out of this.”

“Mr. Greene still won’t like it,” Galvanize said. “But he can’t say we didn’t do as the company ordered, so perhaps he can just deal with it.”

Hexcellent let out a long whistle. “That was about as close as our fearless leader gets to telling corporate to go fuck themselves with a pineapple. Well damn, if Galvanize is willing to piss off the handlers, then I don’t see any reason why the rest of us would turn down the chance to stir the pot. Just tell me you’ve got some sort of plan, Titan.”

“Plan is a bit of a stretch,” Owen admitted. “More like an idea, or a series of partly-formed ideas that might form a whole one. We’ll probably still lose, you all know that going in, but I think you can hold out long enough to put on a good show.”

“You’re in luck,” Bubble Bubble said as she leaned in, prompting the others to mirror her movement and collecting them in a makeshift huddle. “Putting on a show is one thing this team definitely knows how to do.”

The whispers started softly, mere confusion, not yet fully-formed. Soon bewilderment turned to speculation, and as it did the whispers grew, snaking about in the silence between cheers. Eventually, the whispers began to overtake the yells as more and more people stared down at the three figures approaching the rope, none of them a near-giant of a man with legendary strength.

“You really think they have a shot?” Zone asked, carefully watching the crowd as they scrutinized his teammates.

“At winning? It’s not likely. The people here haven’t exactly been wimps. But this kind of event isn’t just about raw power. Footing and grip also come heavily into play. On at least one of those, we’re going to have a clear advantage, plus a little oomph of our own pulling. The odds that it will allow them to snare victory are slim, but they shouldn’t go down easy. That might be enough.” Owen tried to sound more optimistic than he actually felt; the truth of the matter was that without having tested the other team himself, there was no way of knowing how powerful they were. It was entirely possible they could win the match in seconds, humiliating everyone on his team. That was life, though. There were always risks, always unknowns. At least the others knew what they were getting in to.

“Oh, what’s this? It seems our local PEERS team has pulled their Hero Liaison out of the rotation for this turn,” Jade announced. She skittered over to where the next match was being set up, ignoring the one currently in progress. No one in the crowd seemed to object, as their attention had also been stolen by this unexpected roster change. “That’s a . . . bold strategy. Can one of you tell me what prompted such a decision?”

“What do you mean? We saw everyone else switching people, so we just thought that was what we were supposed to do. Did we make a whoopsie?” Hexcellent’s voice was dripping with both sarcasm and an almost infantile naivety. A few titters of laughter could be heard as the crowd tried to pair the sickly sweet voice with the smirking girl in heavy makeup. There was no telling how long she would have milked it, but Galvanize stepped in before she got a chance.

“We just wanted to give the people a good show so they got their

money's worth," Galvanize replied. "And while Titan is unquestionably the strongest of us, he's also only one member of our team. We decided it was time to spice things up a bit."

"Interesting. I'm assuming one of you also has enhanced strength then?" Jade sounded polite but skeptical as she looked the three competitors over.

"Not directly, no, but since you made the rules so flexible, we do have a way to fill that need." Galvanize gave a nod to Hexcellent, who couldn't quite resist rubbing her hands together with glee.

Slowly, she parted those hands and lifted them into the air, muttering softly under her breath. Owen knew she could use her ability without all the showboating, but he didn't begrudge her a little theatricality in this sort of situation. They were, after all, trying to win the crowd, not the match.

A familiar burst of smoke suddenly appeared, and when it dissipated many members of the crowd let out gasps and a few half-muffled shrieks. Big Henry was a bit unsettling the first time anyone saw him. Hexcellent's demon paid the crowd no mind as he reached down and picked up the end of the rope. He didn't seem to grimace from the effort, and Owen let out a small sigh of relief. If Big Henry couldn't even handle the rope, they were pretty much done for.

"See, we've still got a strongman to pull for us." Galvanize was flashing the pearly whites and turning up the charm, waving to the crowd as they tried to figure out what to make of a demon suddenly appearing on the field. "And not to worry folks, he's harmless. Or he's as harmless as Hexcellent, so you can all make your own judgments there." More laughter this time, as the crowd's nerves settled and they got used to Big Henry.

"Anyway, I think we're about to begin, so if you don't mind, we'll all get in position." Galvanize turned away from Jade to where his team was clustered together. It was far enough away that she almost didn't catch his next words, but they still managed to crackle through the intercom.

"Okay everybody, remember: **do your best.**"

Owen was glad Galvanize could target his power; otherwise he'd have just brought everyone in the stadium, opponents included, to their peak level. Instead, only Hexcellent, Bubble Bubble, and Big Henry got the boost, each of them standing a little straighter as his words worked their magic. Galvanize took his spot at the front of the rope while Hexcellent went to stand next to

Big Henry. She couldn't pull with him, that would be more than three people, but she did still need to stand near her proxy.

Bubble Bubble, however, made no attempt to grab the rope. Instead, she walked around her other teammates, summoning spheres of energy on the ground directly in front of them. Foot by foot, Galvanize and Big Henry braced themselves against her orbs, until she called forth a final pair on the ground for herself. Pressing her feet against them, Bubble Bubble took hold of the rope and flashed the audience a brief, measured smile.

"Well folks, this match will certainly be different, no doubt about that," Jade said, finally moving away from the team of oddballs. She walked across to the match still in progress, a hard-fought one where neither team had been giving or gaining more than a few inches at a time. Fatigue, however, had finally set in, and bit by bit one team was dragging the other forward.

Owen watched, not caring who won the bout, only knowing that as soon as their match ended his team's would begin. None of the ones holding the rope spared any glances for what was happening around them. They were all braced, ready, and focused completely on the task at hand. Even if they couldn't win, they were going to fight like it was still on the table.

It was one of the many stubborn qualities he admired about his team.

The first tug of the match nearly cost Owen's team everything. Their opponents put a lot of power into the opening move, clearly intent on throwing the weaker Supers off balance and claiming an early lead. It nearly worked, too. Only Big Henry's stalwart readiness coupled with Bubble Bubble's footholds kept them in the game, as the lumbering demon halted their movement forward and brought the match to a state of momentary equilibrium.

Now that they had a chance to react, Galvanize and Bubble Bubble both dug their heels in, pulling with all they had, using their whole bodies as wedges. The match would ultimately depend on Big Henry, but, unlike when Titan was at their backs, they knew every little bit they could add would make a difference. In seconds, both were sweating from the effort of staving off a team of strongmen, Bubble Bubble's makeup smearing around her eyes as she gritted her teeth and continued to pull.

"Well now, look at this. Seems like the team of PEERS is able to hold their own even without their Hero Liaison. But how long can they keep it up?" Jade stood near the center line, the point which would mark the failure for one of the teams. It seemed she was going to be there at the exact moment this match was decided, and from the way the crowd seemed to be leaning in, they no doubt wished they had her vantage point as well.

Every member of the Mordent Holdings team was visibly shaking with effort. Even Hexcellent, standing on the sidelines, had her eyes narrowed and fists clenched as she willed Big Henry to pull with every ounce of power he could muster. By contrast, the other team seemed to be giving it quite a bit of effort, but they weren't exhausting themselves. Owen couldn't blame them; why would they? From the outset, it was clear that all the PEERS were doing was buying time, going down with a fight. At their very best, giving all they had, the most they could manage was to hold the rope steady. No, the other team would wait until the PEERS tired themselves out then drag Galvanize across the line for a simple victory, preserving energy for their next match. It was the smart move, tactically.

Of course, there were always more than one set of tactics at play in any engagement.

The first cheers came less than a minute after the match had started. It was a mishmash of syllables as people tried to yell the names Galvanize, Hexcellent, and Bubble Bubble on top of each other all at once. Eventually, someone hit upon the idea of just chanting “PEERS,” and in seconds it had caught on like wildfire. Soon, whole sections of the crowd were cheering for the straining, sweating figures that were barely holding on. They hadn’t exactly won over everyone, but it was a far cry from what had happened when Titan was on the rope.

Owen smiled to himself as he watched uncertainty ripple through the players of the Cincinnati Cyborgs that were holding the opposite end of the rope. It was a hard and fast rule every Hero learned in their first years on the job: people always liked to cheer for an underdog. It was what they identified with, what movies and television had taught them to believe in. David was always more fun to root for than Goliath, which was precisely why Titan had made such a boring competitor to watch.

True as that was, though, underdogs were underdogs for a reason, and life didn’t often echo the fable-like stories of triumph people adored. Slowly but surely the stalemate ended and Owen’s team began to move forward. Bubble Bubble pushed her orbs along with them, allowing them to keep their footholds as they were dragged, but even that wasn’t enough to turn the tides. Their opponents were stronger: always had been. But they’d put up a good fight, and Owen was proud of them now that it was over.

Except. . . it wasn’t over. They were still being dragged, there was no doubt about that, but not a one of them seemed to have accepted their fate. Galvanize leaned back, straining with every fiber of muscle contained in his body. Bubble Bubble was pulling so hard that her pale, freckled face had gone completely flushed. Sweaty red hair was matted to her forehead, the sort of sight she would have never allowed cameras to glimpse before. Even Hexcellent was right next to Big Henry, whispering encouragement in the demon’s ear as it grunted and strained against the combined might of its opponents. They were losing and they knew it, but each one of them was still fighting like they had a chance to turn things around.

The crowd, fickle though it could be, had taken note of their efforts, and the cheering in the stands reflected it. Everyone knew the eventual outcome, yet the harder Owen’s team fought to deny it, the more those in the stands loved them. Even Owen felt impressed and surprised by the depth of their determination. This was more than he’d expected them to give, to be capable of giving, and if it hadn’t been in bad taste he would have cupped his



hands to his mouth and screamed for them right along with the crowd.

Owen was seconds away from saying to hell with bad taste and cheering anyway when the match finally came to an end. Galvanize, moving his leg backward to adjust his stance, slipped, and was dragged several inches forward, sending his foot across the line. A whistle blew, and the rope fell to the ground.

“Looks like our winners for this match are the players from the Cincinnati Cyborgs!” Jade announced. Their triumph was greeted with applause, a dimmed sound compared to the yelling that had been taking place only moments prior. Luckily for all involved, Jade wasn’t a novice. She knew the importance of keeping a crowd pumped and exactly how to make sure they stayed that way.

“And let’s have one more round of applause for their competitors, the team of PEERS-”

Jade was cut off by the screaming enthusiasm of the crowd. Yes, they still did and always would like Heroes and sports stars better, but for that moment it didn’t matter. In this coliseum, all that mattered was who put on the better show. And in that regard, a demon, energy orbs, and visible effort definitely made for more interesting entertainment.

“Well, that went exactly as expected,” Hexcellent said. She was the only one of the three who could speak without panting, as Galvanize and Bubble Bubble were both trying to catch their breath. “Greene’s going to be pissed.”

“I don’t know about that,” Owen replied. “Let’s see how the coverage comes out before we assume we’re in trouble. Worse comes to worse, we’ll tell him I refused to go out and you all did the best you could.”

“You know he won’t buy that,” Zone said.

“Probably not, but he already dislikes me, so he’ll happily let me be blamed.” Owen nodded to the field, where Wild Bucks were getting into position for their next match. “Now let’s be good sports and watch the rest of the contest. Some of these are bound to be interesting.”

Only four teams were left, Wild Bucks being one of them, but Owen would not be around to see the results. He had his eyes trained on the field when he heard a familiar voice tickle his right ear. He betrayed nothing as it spoke, though his eyes turned across the field to Deadlift, who met his gaze. Owen gave a slight, nearly imperceptible shake of his head, and then turned to face his team.

“I have to head out for a bit. There’s a situation, I’m tough, you all know the drill.” He kept his tone neutral, almost bored, as if he’d forgotten to pick up milk and was now saddled with making a trip to the store.

“The duty of a Hero is never done,” Galvanize said, giving Owen a knowing smile. “We’ll be sure to make apologies for you in any post-event interviews.”

“Ten bucks says he’s faking it just to ditch the press,” Hexcellent ventured.

Owen said nothing, merely rose from his spot on the bench with his team and jogged off the field. Only when he was safely below the stadium did he speak, and this time it wasn’t to anyone nearby. At least, not so far as he was aware.

“Dispatch, this is Titan. I’m clear from being overheard. Deadlift and his team are staying at the tug-of-war to keep from panicking the crowd. What’s the situation?”

“Three companies of robots, all approaching the city from different directions,” Dispatch said, somehow still calm despite the news she was relaying. “One seems to be en route to Brewster’s downtown, one is moving north with destination unknown, and the third. . .” Her voice, always careful and detached, wavered for the barest of moments. “The third is on track to arrive at the charity event within fifteen minutes.”

“Sweet Jesus, we’ve got a couple thousand people here,” Owen muttered, turning back to look at his team. “Give me their coordinates, I’ll intercept that one.”

“Negative, those are not your orders,” Dispatch replied. “You are to

group up with Jeremiah, Gale, and Aether to meet the robots heading for downtown. Modus Operandi has begun efforts to track the central signal that controls the robots; getting closer to them will expedite the process. Once the target is located, your team is to move immediately to take out the controller.”

“I’m not leaving my team or these civilians unprotected.” Owen stood in the bottom floor of the stadium, listening to all of the people moving around above him. There were more outside, a thousand or so individuals with no idea what danger was marching toward them.

“Nor would anyone ask you to,” Dispatch told him. “We’ve got three other Hero teams already heading to your location, plus Wild Bucks will be on defensive duty after Deadlift leaves to join up with your group. They will easily be in place long before the robots arrive, and I should add that many are better suited to protection and handling multiple enemies than you are.” She wasn’t quite snippy—Dispatch never veered that far off course—but it was clear from her tone that she didn’t appreciate being questioned.

“That’s. . . fine. I mean, good. Sorry, Dispatch. I’m just worried. Can I at least tell my team to evacuate?”

“You need to be moving, Titan. Your team is safer there, under the protection of trained Heroes, than they would be navigating the streets. All other communication networks have already gone down, just as expected. Jeremiah believes that we are only seeing their first move of the day. We have no idea where the next one will come from, or what it will be.”

“Shit.” Owen began moving once more, jogging forward out of the stadium and into the bright afternoon light of the fairgrounds. “Do we even know what they’re after yet?”

“Currently, there is only speculation,” Dispatch said. “However, as downtown is a location where an attack will draw immediate response, and given the current composition of people in the fairgrounds, Modus Operandi has put forth the theory that they are seeking out situations that have the greatest concentrations of Supers.”

“More refinement?” Owen jumped to the side to avoid a small crowd as he hurried through an exit gate. In spite of the need to move, he made sure to give them an apologetic wave and reassuring smile. If people panicked or caught wind that things were wrong before the other Heroes were in position, the whole place could fall into chaos. That was why Deadlift had to finish the contest: they needed to keep people from realizing things were headed south.

“It is possible. The second most likely possibility is that the refinement has been finished, and this is the end-game.”

“No way. . . someone is trying to purge Brewster? That seems spectacularly ill-advised.” Owen raced down the streets, now officially out of the fairgrounds and able to stop pretending he wasn’t rushing for all he was worth.

“True, but no logical strategy makes sense with these tactics so far,” Dispatch agreed. “The DVA is calling in as many Heroes as possible to Brewster to assist with the attack. Currently, the orders are to protect the civilians, destroy the robotic troops, and try and discern what their main objective is.”

“In that order?” Owen asked.

“For everyone else, yes. Your team is to prioritize location of the controller and its destruction above all else,” Dispatch informed him. “Though, until that location is found, you are to work in the same way as all the other Heroes.”

“Guess that’s something.” He understood the need for the greater good; no Hero could save everyone, so they had to prioritize saving as many as they could. That said, Owen had never found peace with ignoring people in need. He still did it, because that was how he saved thousands at the cost of dozens, but it still ate at him every time he had to do so. At least he could do his part for a while. Hopefully, by the time they were supposed to split off, things would be under control enough that the other Heroes could handle it.

Owen sprinted down the street, hurdling intersections with the barest of effort, doing his best to ignore the stares as he leapt over cars and people. All thoughts of discretion went out of his mind as he barreled across the roads. There was no telling how long it would be before the attack started, but every moment of delay had the very real risk of costing someone else their life. He refused to be too late to help.

No matter what, when the robots arrived, Titan would be there to greet them.

Downtown Brewster, while not fully recovered from the most recent battle, was in substantially better shape than Owen had last seen it. Whether it stayed that way for long would depend in equal measures on luck and the costumed men and women who were already gathered in front of him, many transporting civilians out of the area in large groups. Seeing the humans being evacuated eased Owen's nerves a touch; he'd been in enough metropolitan battles to know that sheltering in place wasn't always a safe strategy. With the normal people gone, the Heroes would be free to focus on neutralizing the threat, and that would be safer for everyone.

Most of the other Heroes were familiar to Owen in that he'd seen them in his research, though he couldn't always pair a name with a costume. Several, however, he was certain didn't usually work Brewster. It appeared that Dispatch was right: the DVA had decided to swell their ranks. Were he a younger man with a more vulnerable sense of pride, Owen might have felt slighted at the idea that what Brewster had on hand wouldn't be enough. Instead, he merely thanked whatever divine force was watching over them for the extra help. These robots could be a handful, and the presence of every able body available would mean less death and destruction.

Spotting his temporary team was easy enough, since Gale was hovering in place ten feet off the ground, eyes closed and hands lifted skyward. While he didn't know exactly what she was doing, Owen could still read the mood well enough to approach slowly, lest he disturb something important. Aether and Jeremiah both turned as he approached, the latter holding up a finger to his lips, then whispering, "She's trying to get a sense of where they're coming from."

"How?" Owen's tone matched Jeremiah's, as soft as he could make it while still being heard.

"Feeling the air currents, seeing if they hit unnatural obstacles," Jeremiah explained. "Can't do it for people, but a giant herd of robots would be distinctive."

"You both know I can hear you and that I don't actually need silence, right?" Gale opened one eye and glared down at them before turning her face skyward once more.

“Huh, you don’t? I sort of just assumed.” Jeremiah shrugged and went back to a normal voice, forgoing the gentle whispers. “Anyway, Dispatch has been tracking the robots’ general movement, but there are limits to how much detail she can get us. Once Gale determines exactly where the attack is coming from, we smash up the first wave since the damn things always come in multiple waves, but try to keep at least one functional. My people are doing their best to track the signal, but so far they’re not having any luck, which means our best shot is to tap into one that’s still active.”

From his pocket, Jeremiah produced a device that looked roughly like a ballpoint pen someone had covered in glue and rolled in electronic debris. “Assuming I can figure out which part of the robot is the receiver and jam this in, we’ll have our location in less than a minute.”

“Can’t you just sift through the wreckage of one?” Aether asked. “These things don’t go down easy and keep fighting as long as they’ve got limbs and power.”

“Wouldn’t do me any good. As soon as the robot is down it deactivates itself, burning out its receiver,” Jeremiah said. “We’ve gone through the remains of nearly a hundred and it’s the same every time, nothing but a burned out box of circuits. Hell of a self-preservation mechanism, I have to say.”

“Then how do you know it won’t self-destruct when you try and jam that pen in it?” Owen asked.

“We don’t. Shit, given how well they’re built, the damn things will almost certainly do just that. But if it does work, then it makes our job way easier and saves a lot of people. Seems like a gamble worth taking, don’t you think?” Jeremiah seemed oddly sincere with the question, as though he’d listen to whatever objections Owen could voice. The big man had none, however, because Jeremiah was right. Even if it would probably fail, there was little risk to trying, and the payoff was high enough that it justified the time spent.

“When the first wave is broken, I’ll snap the limbs off one and hold down its torso,” Owen offered. “It might still have some tricks up its sleeve, though, so be careful.”

“Don’t worry, I’m a lot tougher than I look,” Jeremiah replied. “Might even be tougher than you.”

Before Owen could call into question the likelihood of that, Dispatch’s

voice sounded in his ear. “Titan, I wanted to let you know that the first defensive teams are in place at the fairgrounds, and that Deadlift is headed in your direction. He’s being brought by a Hero with flying abilities, so arrival should occur in less than three minutes.”

“Thanks, Dispatch.” His team was safely under the protection of fellow Heroes, and the last member of their hunting party was en route. It wasn’t ideal—no situation where masses of destructive robots were about to attack could be—but it was as good as he could hope for. Part of him wished he could be with the PEERS to make sure they were safe, but they were in good hands. Aside from the Heroes present, they were plenty strong and smart themselves. He trusted in them to survive and to help where they were needed. If the tug-of-war had shown him only one thing, it was that none of those kids were the type to just roll over and die. Which reminded him. . .

“Hey Dispatch, you don’t happen to know who won that tug-of-war event, do you?”

“My understanding is that the Wild Bucks took the final win of the competition, although it was a tough one.”

“I’ll have to congratulate Deadlift when he gets here,” Owen muttered.

“Yeah, that might need to wait a bit.” Gale’s eyes were open again, and she was lowering herself to the ground. Cupping her hands to mouth, she yelled her next words, which were miraculously carried on the burst of wind she sent out at the same time.

“Everyone! Robots are approaching from the southeast and will probably break into view around Eighth Street. If you’re a Hero, prepare for battle. If you’re a civilian still here, start running north. There’s a lot of them coming and they’ll arrive in less than two minutes!”

“That is a damn handy trick,” Owen told her, shifting his view to the street where robots would soon be appearing.

“It’s useful, but a little more imprecise than I’d like.” Gale, always confident and sure in herself, chewed on her bottom lip and glanced at the sky nervously. “Dispatch, are we seeing any movement besides the robots? Something big coming from the east?”

Though he hadn’t been the one to ask the question, Dispatch’s reply still crackled in his ear. “Negative, based on our surveillance and satellites

everything is clear. Do you have other information?”

“No, I just thought I might have felt something,” Gale replied. “It was only for a moment, though. Like I said, trying to use air currents as a sensor is imprecise.”

A high-pitched whine filled the air, and the unmistakable sound of metal feet pounding on pavement echoed toward them from the southeast. All eyes turned as muscles tightened and abilities were made ready.

“Imprecise or not,” Owen said. “It looks like you got this part right.”

The explosion from behind him, to the northwest, took everyone by surprise. A horde of robots erupted upward from under the streets, immediately attacking the Heroes nearest to them. Seconds later, the wave they’d been expecting burst into view, and just like that the collection of Supers was flanked on both sides by their enemy.

No one had time to curse or throw blame or even try and understand all that had happened. In moments, their entire plan had been shot to shit. Now, all they could do was fight to survive.



It was supposed to be controlled, safe, and defended. That was what the Heroes had told them as they arrived, assuring everyone that if they all grouped together in the small stadium, they would be protected from the impending robots. No one really believed they'd be perfectly secure, of course. Living in a world with Supers and Heroes had taught them that safety was a fleeting, impermanent thing. But they also knew the Heroes guarding them would lay down their lives to protect everyone. It would be scary and dangerous, but there would be control. Then the second group of robots had appeared, breaking out from underground with an explosion and pouring up like ants from a freshly-stomped hill. And just like that, it all turned to madness.

Bubble Bubble was forming spheres around groups of civilians, offering what meager protection she could from the sudden onslaught of mechanical monsters. It would have been a futile effort, save for the fact that the robots seemed uninterested in humans. They set themselves directly on course with every Super in a costume or SAA uniform, almost entirely ignoring those without powers. Bubble Bubble soon had to pop a sphere around herself as she tried to fend off a trio that set their sights on her.

Help quickly arrived in the form of Big Henry. Hexcellent was clinging to the creature's back as he smashed his mighty fists into the metallic flesh of those trying to break into Bubble Bubble's sphere. Strong as he was, these things were no slouches either, and as he drew more of their attention, they began to swarm him.

Hexcellent barely had time to cry out before Zone, holding a javelin he'd likely dug out of some supply closet, leapt into the fray and speared a robot through the neck. It turned to strike him, which was just enough of a distraction for Big Henry to grip its head and tear it off the mechanical torso. The other two robots began to attack Big Henry once more, but a giant scaly hand wrapped around each one and lifted them upward. Before either could counterattack, they were bitten clean in two by the crushing jaws of a lizard monster who tossed them to the side.

"You okay?" Its growl sounded like the sort of thing one heard in the darkest nightmares before waking in a cold sweat, but at that moment it was easily the most beautiful voice any of the three could remember. They

nodded, trying to get their bearings and figure out what was happening around them.

The stadium was a sea of chaos, robots and Supers duking it out everywhere. While the Heroes had clearly been taken by surprise, they were managing to regroup bit by bit, wiping out the robots in wide swaths as they worked to get the humans to safety. In one corner of the stadium, a man in a simple gray mask who looked about retirement age had been left alone. It would have been worrying if not for the fact that a veritable graveyard of smashed robots littered the ground at his feet. Those that remained were approaching him very carefully.

“My name is Kaiju,” the monster said, drawing their attention back. “I’m a friend of Titan.”

“I have never been so thankful for his schmoozing as I am right now,” Zone muttered.

“Hang on, where’s Galvanize?” Bubble Bubble said, eyes sweeping the field as she realized they’d lost their leader.

“Making the rounds,” Kaiju informed her. He stretched out a claw and pointed across the stadium’s field. “And probably making a hell of a difference.”

Sure enough, there was Galvanize, darting in and out of battle with such recklessness that Mordent’s insurance people would have shit a chicken if they’d seen him. He was bounding between groups of Supers and humans alike, pausing only long enough to speak briefly to them before moving on to the next cluster of people. Wherever he went, the effects could be seen, as blows became heavier and dodges more precise. Galvanize couldn’t make people any better than their best, but there was still a lot to be said for having every Super in the stadium fighting at peak form.

“He’s how I knew where to find you all,” Kaiju explained. “Though Juiced and I were already looking. Titan helped us out when no one else would, so we’re sure as shit not going to let anything happen to his team.” Another robot turned to face them, but before it could contemplate an attack, Kaiju was on it, turning the thing into scrap before there was even a chance to react. “But damn, I love what that Galvanize guy can do. Wish we had an enhancer on Wild Bucks.”

“Don’t put any ideas in his head,” Hexcellent said. “So what’s the plan, oh mighty Hero? Just keep fighting the robots here all day?”

“Too dangerous,” Kaiju replied. “They always come in waves, and since they seem to have found a way to move underground, we can’t risk staying clustered together like this. Current orders are for us to take out as much of this wave as we can and then begin evacuating all non-Heroes. Their attacks are pretty focused, at least for the moment, so if we can get you out of the hot zones then you should be okay.”

“Sure, you just have to crush a whole wave of robots that took you by surprise before the next one gets here, piece of cake.” Hexcellent was all but clinging to Big Henry, even as Kaiju worked to keep the area around them clear.

“This looks worse than it is. We’ve got a lot of people here whose powers are built for handling groups of attackers. Plus, the brunt of the attack seems to have hit downtown from what we’re hearing. And, in the mother of all fuck-ups, the robots didn’t realize that one of the HCP deans was here. Trust me, within ten minutes we’ll have cleared a path out. It’s the others you should be worried about; they’ve got three times this many robots attacking them.”

“Is downtown where Titan went?” Bubble Bubble asked.

“Yeah; seems they were called over to stop one wave and got taken by surprise just like us,” Kaiju told her.

“Then why bother worrying?” She released the sphere around herself and pulled in Hexcellent before creating a new, larger one. “If he’s there, they’ll be fine.”

Kaiju turned his giant reptilian head toward her and cocked it slightly to the side. “Look, I know Titan is strong and all, but even he has limits.”

“Spoken like someone who hasn’t worked with him for the past few months,” Zone said.

“My thoughts exactly,” Hexcellent agreed. “Downtown is going to be fine, so let’s just focus on getting this place clear and moving everyone to safety.” Big Henry reached over and lifted the sphere in one hand, setting it on his shoulder.

“Zone and Kaiju, lead us out,” Hexcellent ordered. “We’ll bubble and carry as many people as we can along the way.”

“You know, I’m the one who’s a Hero,” Kaiju pointed out.

“And I’m the one who does rescue work every fucking day. Which does this look more like to you? Now either take out your scaly cock so we can have Zone get the measuring tape out to formally settle this or help us get clear.” Hexcellent put her hands on her hips and stared Kaiju down, nearly eye level from her spot atop Big Henry’s back. Eventually the giant lizard monster let out a snort and began lumbering forward.

“I was just making a point, no need to be mean about it.” In any other situation, they would have laughed mercilessly at the massive creature growling out a passive aggressive grumble. But that would, hopefully, come later. For now, there was only the job at hand.

In battle, everything was madness. Maybe it was different for other Heroes, the ones who could soar above and see the whole field or those with minds quick enough to calculate every variable as it entered their awareness. But Owen wasn't that kind of Hero, or Super, or man. He'd always been the type with his boots on the ground, slogging through the blood and chaos one heavy step at a time. Only when guided did he have any objective beyond moving forward. There was no greater plan at work, or if one existed, he hadn't been let in on it. Today, Owen didn't try to calculate or scheme or even bother with thought. He simply did what seemed most appropriate: destroy every robot he could get his hands on. Much as he might be lacking in the grander abilities, when it came to that task, he was *damned* good at what he did.

Two robots jumped on him from the left, one with an open mouth full of teeth like needles and the other with arms crackling with energy. The designer had changed things up this time around, giving the robots different specialties instead of making them interchangeable. While it meant every bot wasn't the best fit for every situation, it also made fighting them more dangerous, as one never knew what the next opponent was capable of. Case in point: the ones with needle teeth had managed to tear through the flesh of many a Hero's armor and extra-durable skin already. The teeth were probably some sort of high-tech gizmo specifically designed to cut through even the densest of materials.

Owen threw his right forearm into the needle-filled mouth as his left grabbed the energy wielder by the torso. If the thing was going to get a piece of him, better it be a non-vital chunk. As for the energy bot, Owen had taken every burn, disintegration, and jolt that the Super community could throw at him during his Hero days. Odds were good that this wasn't so new that it would get past his existing defenses. The needles shredded through his costume easily, and while he could feel them scratching at his skin, they failed to pierce the barrier of flesh.

"Too bad, looks like someone beat you to it." Owen could have sworn he saw a look of surprise in the robot's fixed facial features, but an instant later he'd whipped the needle-filled head into the bot crackling with energy, smashing both up and then tearing them to small chunks. The one trait these

did all seem to have was the ability to self-repair, which not a single Hero present was giving them the chance to do.

All around Owen the battle raged. Beams of energy tore apart metal frames, explosions rocked the streets and buildings, and all manner of costumed combatants could be seen bounding to and fro as they spotted new targets or friends in need. The familiar form of a hawk made out of plasma caught Owen's eye as it dipped and dove, carving through the robots like they were formed from wet sand. Granite wasn't too far off, tearing apart every robot that stepped near him while protecting the summoner guiding the energy bird. In the center of the sky, surrounded by a hurricane of robot debris, was Gale, whose blasts of wind broke enemy formations before they could fully form.

There were plenty of others who Owen didn't know, but they were holding their own nonetheless. A Hero with red hair had pulled out a pair of swords and was slicing up her opponents without missing a step. A duo in matching costumes was taking turns throwing one another, leaving a smoking trail in their wake that reminded Owen of Bullrush. A woman in a green and black costume was somehow freezing clusters of robots in place while a man wearing a purple suit calmly stepped through them and touched their torsos. The moment they unfroze, every bot he touched exploded into scrap, leaving charred husks behind.

The Heroes were better and stronger, there was no doubt about that, but the robots were seemingly endless. For every one the Heroes downed, three seemed to burst out of the ground. If they were being swarmed, that would be bad enough, but the situation was actually worse. Owen had personally seen several units split off and run away from the battle, which meant there were probably a lot more he'd missed. With so many Heroes just dealing with the horde, the ones that escaped were free to run amok and tear up the town. Of course, that was presuming that destruction was their end goal, which Owen knew was a pretty big assumption. It was maddening how little they actually knew. Luckily, Owen had plenty of easy targets to vent that annoyance on.

Three steps brought him to another robot, this one trying to sneak up on a Hero already dealing with two others. Owen grabbed it by the waist and ripped it neatly in half, then reached over to pop the head off another. The Hero, a short woman whose costume bore a skull on the mask, gave a quick nod of thanks before finishing off her remaining opponent with a single kick. It began to rust at her touch, corroding and collapsing into nothingness within

seconds. She didn't bother to talk as she rushed off to find more robots, nor did he expect her to. There was nothing to be said, unless it was strategic. In a fight like this, everyone did their best and looked out for one another when they could. Maybe later, when things were finally settled, there would be time for gratitude and buying each other rounds of drinks.

Another robot stepped forward, but before Owen could so much as touch it, a breeze blew past him. Along with the gust of wind came a dozen of those needle teeth, crudely pried from their owner's jaws, shredding the other robot before it had a chance to react.

"I've got to get a stockpile of these," Gale said, floating down next to Owen as the needles made their way back around, landing lightly in her hand. "They cut through anything."

"Almost." Owen held up his arm showing her the torn costume and the red, but unbroken, patch of skin.

"Why am I not surprised?" Gale muttered. Around them, a new tornado began to form, whisking up all the chunks of beaten robot and turning them into projectiles that would smash apart anyone who tried to get too close. "Anyway, I wanted you to know that as soon as this wave slackens, we're going to make the attempt to crack one of these things open. You need to start fighting your way north toward Jeremiah so that everyone will be in place when it's time."

"That's fine, but why didn't he just tell me through Dispatch?" Owen asked.

"Because at this range, he thinks the robots can overhear us talking and adapt their strategy based on what we say. Hence my noisy little barrier." Gale held up her hand and gestured to the swirling storm engulfing them, as if there were any question of what she was talking about.

"Got it. Anything else I need to know?"

"You've probably already noticed, but the fucking things are spreading. Dispatch has already had to peel some Heroes off to deal with the ones that left this fight. They're doing their best, but. . . well, you can count. We can't leave this scene, obviously, but if you see any trying to escape, do everyone a favor and discourage them."

"I like to think I can be an excellent demotivator when the occasion demands," Owen replied.

“Then show them what you’ve got. I need to go find Aether and pass along the message. Remember, go north and stop the rogues on the way.” With that, the tornado suddenly came to an end and Gale was gone, racing through the sky as she searched for the woman darting through solid objects.

With the wind wall removed, Owen could see how the landscape had shifted and that new clusters of robots had gotten near them in the brief window of concealment. Flexing his hands, he set his sight on the nearest ones and bolted toward them, not bothering to try and land properly. His body was a weapon in itself, and he planned to use it as one, leaving a trail of destroyed robots in his mighty wake.



Hexcellent wasn't sure why she'd thought things would be better once they were outside the stadium; it had just seemed like the way these sorts of events were supposed to play out. Someone would have a plan, and they'd be rushed off to safety with the other civilians. Getting out of the stadium and then off the fairgrounds were the first steps toward freedom. Except once they made it outside, following the path cut by Wild Bucks and other Heroes who'd shown up to help, their world made even less sense.

At least in the stadium there had been a sort of order, with limited entrances and only so much ground to cover. The moment they stepped outside people began to scatter, which was made all the more troublesome by the fact that there were robots roaming about. It took less than a minute for their tight, well-guarded unit to disintegrate as Heroes, including Kaiju, were forced to peel off to meet charging robots or rescue civilians. She and Bubble Bubble had to flee the sphere on Big Henry's shoulder, as the large demon simply couldn't move quickly enough while hauling them to steer clear of the more troublesome spots. As she stepped out into the open again, Hexcellent came to peace with the fact that there was no greater plan in place, or at least not one that involved them. If they wanted saving, they'd have to get themselves out of the fire.

"Time to pick a direction, folks," she said, pointing to the several streets, all with at least one squad of robots near the entrances. "As I see it, our best bets are to try and get the hell out of Brewster proper, maybe flee to the burbs, or make a run for the Mordent Building. We might not be a lot safer there, but personally I'd like to die in my own bed, if that's on the table."

"Mordent is actually very secure," Galvanize pointed out. "It's built to withstand all manner of natural disasters, plus the security is top of the line. Granted, that might not stop all of. . . this." He waved at the robots bounding about and targeting every Super they could find. "But it's a far sight safer than being on the street."

"And what about everyone else?" Bubble Bubble asked. The streets were all but choked with civilians who were barreling out of the fairgrounds, no doubt filled with the same naïve hope as Hexcellent that things would be safer once they were outside.

“We’re probably not authorized to fight these things, but given the situation, it would be hard for anyone to argue that we aren’t acting in self-defense,” Galvanize said. “I’m not the only one who’s noticed they only seem to be going after Supers, right?”

“Sort of.” Hexcellent had noticed the pattern to, though she’d seen it slightly differently. “They’re going after people who mark themselves as Supers. SAA athletes, Heroes, and obviously us. I don’t think they somehow invented a scanner to tell humans from Supers; shit, if they had, they could make billions overnight. I think they’re just going off the markings we’ve put on ourselves.”

“She’s right,” Zone said. “They’ll knock normal folks aside, but it’s only the people in costume or uniform that they target.”

“Okay then.” Galvanize surveyed the layout of the chaos before them, his mind whirling as he tried to put together what little information they had and turn it into a plan for survival. “Zone, take off your shirt. Since that’s where most of your ads are, hopefully you can pass for a normal person once it’s gone.”

“Why only me?” Despite the question, Zone had already begun to strip down. Much as he wanted an explanation, he’d been in more than enough dangerous situations with Galvanize to trust his leader’s orders even before he understood them.

“The rest of us have costumes that are too elaborate; we would never fool them,” Galvanize explained. “You’re going to scout ahead, finding us the clearest route and hiding spots so we can make our way back to the Mordent building. If we see any civilians in trouble along the way, we do our best to save them and bring them along. As long as they don’t stand too close to us, they aren’t likely to get targeted.”

“Yeah, but how do we-”

Hexcellent was cut off as a giant, demonic hand slammed itself into her back and pushed her to the ground. Big Henry stepped in where she’d been standing, raising its gauntlet-like hands over its chest moments before a blast of red energy struck. Big Henry let out a massive roar as its flesh began to pucker and sear. To the monster’s credit, it held out for nearly a full ten seconds before the damage became too great and it disintegrated into a cloud of smoke. Ten seconds, paltry though it was in the scheme of the universe, proved to be long enough for a member of the Cincinnati Cyborgs, one of the

very Supers they'd gone up against in the tug-of-war, to slam a powerful shoulder into the robot and knock it to pieces.

Big Henry was gone and Hexcellent rose to her feet slowly, gripping the side of her skull, visibly in pain. Summoners took a healthy bit of mental feedback when their creations were destroyed, and the more powerful they were, the more it hurt. Bubble Bubble was already at her teammate's, her friend's, side as Hexcellent managed to slowly steady herself.

"I was going to ask how we chat with Zone, since no one brought comms to a charity event, but that fucker robot just solved the problem for us." Hexcellent held out her hand and Impers appeared on Zone's now-bare shoulder, trying not to hook its small claws into his tan skin. "Impers will run relay between Zone and us, so that he can always be scouting."

"Are you sure you wouldn't rather have Huggles on hand?" Zone asked. Big Henry was the best they could ask for, but his destruction meant it would take time and rest before Hexcellent could summon him again.

"Huggles is great, but she's not subtle. I think the more covert we are, the better," Hexcellent replied. She leaned on Bubble Bubble, a fresh wave of pain wracking her skull. Though she didn't tell the others, summoning another creature so soon after losing one intensified the pain. There would be time for beers and bitching later. Right now they needed to survive.

"Okay, I'm going ahead," Zone told them, jogging east in the direction of the Mordent Building. "I'll find a way past all the robots guarding the exit streets, you three just try and stay safe until Impers comes back."

Hexcellent chuckled darkly under her breath, eyes taking in the destruction and bloodshed around them. "I could have created a summon with flying powers big enough to carry us years ago, but noooo, I had to be afraid of heights."

"We'll make it back," Galvanize assured her. "I'm sure the Heroes are already taking control of the situation."

Confident though he sounded, it was somewhat hard to believe him when the sounds of raining debris drowned out his words.

Something was wrong. Owen couldn't quite put his finger on what, but as he smashed his way through the intersection stuffed full of robots, ignoring their bites, swipes, and blasts, he could tell that there was an element off about the fight. Another man or a younger version of himself would have shaken the feeling off as nerves or fear, but Owen had been in the fire literally countless times during his tenure as a Hero. He'd made a name for himself by being the one they could drop into any situation, and as a result had gained enough experience to learn the value of trusting his intuition, especially when it so boldly grabbed his attention. If something seemed off about the fight, then it was, even if he couldn't put it into words quite yet.

It certainly wasn't that the battle was too easy, at least for the Heroes as a whole. Granted, nothing the robots had seemed able to hurt him, but he was just one man. Containing this many threats required the coordination of dozens of Heroes, many of whom didn't share his invulnerability.

Owen grabbed a robot with whirling blades for arms and smashed it down over his knee, then stomped it to pieces on the ground. Maybe it was that these seemed easier to kill than the previous times he'd faced them. Then again, before they'd been in limited groups and focused on defense. Now, there were so damn many it was nearly impossible to stretch his arm out without smacking one. Perhaps the tradeoff to creating so many had been that they were lower quality; maybe the person in charge had switched tactics and decided to simply try and overrun the Heroes. That seemed viable, though ill-advised. At the rate things were going, they'd manage this first wave in five more minutes, and by the time the next arrived they would have regrouped and prepared.

A Hero in gray and crimson zipped past Owen, so fast they were an unrecognizable blur, leaving a trail of severed robots behind them. No, it wasn't his imagination; these were definitely going down easier. But why? Numbers would make things more troublesome and might bring down a few more civilians, but they were far less likely to kill actual Heroes. It felt like he was on the right mental path to solve the mystery, but he had no idea where to go from here. So he focused on moving his body instead, barreling through a set of robots hobbled by the gray and red blur to finish the job.

Roughly a hundred feet away, he saw Gale settling down for a landing

near a broken streetlight. Seemed like he was almost to his goal, then. Whatever was hitting him as wrong, it would hopefully get resolved when Jeremiah got a lock on these bastards' signal. If they could shut down the source, the robots' plan would be irrelevant. Still, he couldn't shake the feeling something was wrong, so as he punched his fingers through a mechanical torso and hollowed it out, he decided to check on the lone element he couldn't directly influence.

"Dispatch, this is Titan. Can I get a location and condition analysis for my PEERS team?"

Even in the middle of this fight, which was no doubt only one incident among many she was dealing with across the country, Dispatch's reply was instantaneous.

"One moment, Titan, let me see what I can get for you."

Owen finished coring the robots in his hands and reached for the next nearest one, only to realize it was another Hero in a mechanical suit. He gave a small wave of apology, to which the other Hero responded with a curt nod. It was hard to blame them for being annoyed. There was no way Owen had been the first Hero to see metal and assume it belonged to an enemy. He quickly turned away, grabbing a robot that was taking aim to blast another Hero with an energy beam and placing his hand over the weapon's muzzle. In seconds, the laser gun had melted to scrap as the beam was unable to escape. Owen quickly dismantled the rest of the bot before it could get its bearings.

"Titan, your team successfully evacuated the fairgrounds under the watch of Kaiju from Wild Bucks. However, once they were out he lost track of them as there were other civilians to protect. Based on satellite imagery, they appear to have slipped away from that concentration of enemies and are currently working their way toward the Mordent Building."

Owen remembered his first day walking into Mordent, taking stock of the cannons disguised as potted plants and knowing it was only the tip of their security iceberg. "Good. I know we've got a lot going on, but if you can, keep an eye on them for me. I want to know when they're home safe."

"You will be kept abreast," Dispatch assured him.

With that as settled as it could be, Owen tore through a half-dozen more robots before finding himself in what was as close to a clearing as he'd seen since the fight started. Gale, Deadlift, Aether, and Jeremiah were all gathered together, polishing off a few mechanical adversaries as he stepped

into view. Aether finished hers off last, phasing her arms through its chest and coming out with several components that were, apparently, quite vital to its operation. It was easy to forget just how terrifying phasers could be, given the right talent and training.

“There’s our big fella,” Jeremiah announced. He somehow still looked composed, barely a hair out of place as he whipped the cane-like object in his hand about. With a flick of his wrist it compressed down and he tucked it neatly away in a compartment of his costume. No great shock that a team full of Subtlety Heroes would have fancy high-tech weapons, though from the smoking remains around his feet, it seemed the cane did far more than just make itself portable.

“We clear enough to do this, or do we need to thin the herd a bit more?” Owen asked. The tide had certainly turned in the Heroes’ favor, but the battle was far from finished. He would be damned if he left people hanging when it could be avoided.

“I think this is as good as we’re likely to get,” Jeremiah replied. “Sooner or later the next wave will show up, better to be ahead of the curve. Gale and Aether, please maintain our perimeter. Deadlift, handle any who get past them. Titan, if you would be so kind as to grab me a subject.”

Owen leapt out of the clearing, grabbing a robot that was already short one bladed arm and snapping off the other. He tore off its legs too, just for good measure, and then carried his prize past Gale, who was already calling a fresh blast of wind to surround them. Setting the torso down on the ground, its head still intact and somehow glaring at them, he motioned for Jeremiah.

“You kept the head on?” he asked, pulling a large knife from another compartment. With a single touch of a button on the side, the blade began to glow a fiery red.

“I don’t know what makes these things register as ‘broken’ but being decapitated seemed like a good bet.” Owen rested one hand on the bot’s metal neck, keeping it pinned just in case it had a trick or two up its sleeve.

“You’d be surprised by how many things that doesn’t work on,” Jeremiah muttered. As he spoke, his hands worked quickly, slicing into the torso with surprising delicacy, easily piercing the metal hide to reveal the robot’s inner workings. He may as well have cracked open a pinball machine for as much as Owen could tell, but Jeremiah seemed to have some idea of what he was looking at. After a few minutes of rooting about, he grabbed a

dark box that Owen thought looked identical to four others also in the torso and yanked out his strange pen.

“On the very likely chance that this blows us up, sorry about the costume.” That was all the warning Jeremiah gave before plunging his pen into the device. Owen tensed, not because he expected the explosion would hurt, but because it would still be a damn explosion. None came, however. Instead, a pale blue light near the top of the pen flashed on, and Jeremiah let out a long sigh of relief.

“Did it work?” Owen asked.

“Maybe, it will still take several minut- Hang on, what?” Jeremiah touched his right ear, the universal signal for being on comms, and as he listened his eyes grew steadily wider. Worse, the smug expression always present on his face vanished, and for the first time since they’d met, Jeremiah looked genuinely worried. Finally, he dropped his hand and with a single stroke of his knife carved up the innards of the robot.

“Guessing something went wrong,” Owen said.

“Not with the device, per se. With the plan as a whole. They saw us coming, the bastards. These robots aren’t being controlled by a central signal. There are six signals spread throughout the city, relays to act as redundancies and mask the real source.”

“Well then, let’s go find those.” Owen pushed to his feet, ready to charge back into battle.

“No need,” Jeremiah said, rising more slowly and pulling his cane back out. “According to what my team said, one of those signals should be landing right on top of us in less than two minutes.”

“What in the tap-dancing fuck is that?” Hexcellent reached out and grabbed Galvanize by the cape, pulling him up short as she pointed to the sky five blocks north of their position.

So far, their plan had been going surprisingly well. The robot forces were scattered enough that Zone was able to sneak the team around the bigger clusters. Between his scouting and Impers running messages, they’d made good progress in getting closer to the Mordent building. For a moment, Hexcellent had allowed herself to feel cautious optimism about their chances of surviving the day.

This was when, almost perfectly on cue, a giant mechanical monster rippled into view and fell from the sky. Hexcellent didn’t know how something that big had managed to stay out of sight; then again, the pinnacle of her technical expertise was switching the television’s input feeds between game systems. She could tell it wasn’t the only one, though. She could see another appear to the south and fall, and she thought she caught a sliver of one to the east. The one nearby, however, she had a perfect view of, and what a view it was.

The thing had a base built like an insect’s. It hosted a half-dozen ultra-thick legs which supported the towering torso, which in turn sported four arms, each ending in what looked like various gun clusters or cannons. The torso itself was heavily fortified, with smaller weapons mounted at regular intervals. A head was perched on the very top, eight glowing eyes spaced out to give what Hexcellent had to imagine was a 360-degree view of its surroundings at all times. Worst of all, which was saying a lot when one watched a giant mechanical monster shatter the concrete as it landed, compartments just above its legs were sliding open to release more of the regular-sized deadly robots.

“What I wouldn’t give to have been born a tech-controller,” Bubble Bubble muttered, stunned as they watched the river of robots pouring out from the massive mother ship.

“Something tells me if that solved the problem, the Heroes would have brought one in ages ago,” Galvanize said. “Hexcellent, can you have Impers bring back Zone? I’ve got a hunch we need to rethink our strategy. I



can't imagine anything that big would have the capability of focusing just on Supers."

"Yeah, not an issue. As soon as I saw the building-sized mech falling from the sky, I figured we'd need to change plays." Zone hopped out from a nearby alley, Impers riding on his shoulder, leaving a small trail of blood where his tiny claws had sank into Zone's shirtless flesh.

"So, that thing probably came to clean house," Hexcellent said. "Which means we need to get the hell away from it, and the troops it has, as quickly as possible. Smart money says this whole block will be gone soon if the Heroes don't intercept it, and even if they do, that's not a fight I want to be near."

"She's right, we need to focus on speed now," Bubble Bubble agreed. "Whoever is doing this clearly plans to level all of Brewster."

Again, Hexcellent felt a tickle in the back of her mind. Why? Unless this was the world's most patient sociopath at work, it didn't make any sense. Criminals acted for a reason: revenge, profit, pride, feeding an addiction, there was almost always purpose behind their motives. This, all of this, it didn't really fit. Maybe if there were a ransom demand or banks being targeted, but it just seemed like random chaos.

Except. . . somehow, it was familiar. She couldn't put a finger on it, yet Hexcellent was certain she'd seen something like this before. Maybe in her darker days, the ones hidden behind a cloud of foggy, drug-coated memories. It was there, darting about in her brain, always just a few inches out of reach.

"Hexcellent," Galvanize repeated, snapping her attention back to the moment. "I asked if you'll have Impers scout for us? It's too dangerous to send Zone, but your demon might slip by undetected."

"Yeah, yeah, no problem." She tried to follow the itch in her brain again, but it was gone, scared off by the rational issues she should be handling. Giving a few quick orders to Impers, she took the demon and tossed it into the sky where it pumped its tiny wings and began to rise.

"Okay, he's going to do a wide sweep of the block, then come back when- FUCK!" Hexcellent grabbed the side of her head, her knees buckling from the burst of pain. If not for Zone reflexively catching her in mid-fall, she'd have been splayed out on the concrete. As it was, her breath came in heavy, ragged gasps, and there were spots in her vision.

“Impers?” Galvanize asked.

Hexcellent could only manage a weak nod. Her brain felt like it had blades running across it. She’d never lost two of her summons in such rapid succession before; it was a whole new level of pain. Dismissing them didn’t hurt in the slightest, but when they were killed, their suffering channeled through the shared link. Each was a part of her, and she felt their destruction on a visceral level. That was why summoners could only have so many creatures, and why the creation of each one took untold effort. One only had so many pieces of their mind to spread around.

“Damn,” Bubble Bubble said. “No more eyes in the sky.”

“At least Zone got back before he was stuck out there,” Galvanize said. “If they saw and shot down Impers, we can assume everything non-metallic is probably a target. At this point, we’ll just have to move fast and hope for the best.”

“Not yet.” Hexcellent pushed herself off Zone’s shoulder, using him as a prop. “We need protection.”

“Forget it, you’re clearly in no shape to summon anymore,” Galvanize told her.

“And will I be in better shape when the robots carve me to pieces?” Hexcellent shot back. “None of us are good in a fight, so we need protection. Something to sacrifice if we need a buffer between us and them. Huggles can be summoned again after I rest. That’s not true for anyone else.”

“Galvanize, she has a point,” Zone agreed. “We might be able to take *one* of those things if we got lucky and worked together. But there’s a lot more than one out there. We’ve got no eyes and no heavy-hitters. We need help.”

Galvanize looked at his team for a long moment before shaking his head. “I don’t like it. I think it’s too risky. But we all know that nothing I say will stop you, so instead of being a naysayer, I’ll offer encouragement. Hexcellent, **do your best.**”

“Thanks, fearless leader.” Hexcellent straightened her back, held out her hand, and set her jaw. “And one of you assholes better carry me if I pass out.”

Dark smoked swirled in front of them, expanding slowly but steadily.

Sweat began to drip down Hexcellent's face as she ignored the pain in her head, which was now turning to an ache that seemed to echo in her bones. She focused on bringing forth the product of her imagination into the real world. She knew every inch of Huggles, every aspect of the demon's being, and she pushed that image to the front of her mind, then further into the cloud of smoke before her.

It took almost twenty seconds, the longest summon Hexcellent had ever done, but when the smoke cleared, the familiar bladed arms of Huggles were there to greet them.

"And that's. . . how you do. . . that." Hexcellent stumbled as she took a step, but Zone and Bubble Bubble both slid their arms beneath her shoulders. She was still conscious, though clearly not by much.

"Team, we need to get out of here, *now*," Galvanize ordered. "Run as quick as you can, avoid the robots whenever possible, and no matter what, don't let anyone fall behind." Without another word, he turned toward Mordent, made a quick motion for them to follow, and took off in a jog just slow enough for them to keep up with as they helped Hexcellent along.

"He better not try to ditch us," Hexcellent said. Zone and Bubble Bubble both chuckled, even though there was nothing funny about what Galvanize was doing. He'd taken the front position because it was the most dangerous.

If anyone were going to be spotted, it would be him, and with as strong as the robots were, that might be a deadly choice.

“Please tell me there’s a backup plan.” Owen watched in wonder as the six-legged metal monster fell from the sky. The beast landed with a thunderous crunch only two blocks away from where he and Jeremiah stood over the carved-up carcass of a smaller robot.

“There is. . . sort of.” Jeremiah yanked his pen-device out of the robot’s chest and slipped it back into a pocket on his costume. “From what my people were able to figure out, the six giant mech-style robots are functioning as relay stations. The universal signal goes to them, and they broadcast it to the lesser robots. It’s a good way to make sure people can’t use one of the pawns to find the king—basically exactly what we were trying to do—but there are two weaknesses to the tactic.”

Jeremiah scanned the area, pointing to two other giant mechs as they fell in their line of sight. “Most importantly, at least for the time being, from the way that the big bots are scattered about, I’d guess there’s a range limit to their relay capacity. That means if we take them down, the smaller ones depending on the signal might be cut off.”

“Won’t be easy, but I think we can swing that,” Owen replied. Already, the Heroes around them were shifting focus, taking note of the new wave of bots that was pouring on to the battlefield from the innards of the giant mech. “What’s the second weakness?”

“Those big ones must be connected to the master signal,” Jeremiah said. “So our original plan is still valid. If I can somehow get access to the receiver inside one of those, we might be able to track down the source.”

Owen sized up the massive opponent that was already firing off rounds of bullets and lasers at every Hero advancing on it. “That is a lot of metal to root through for one little box.”

“Which is why we should focus on knocking out the first five, especially if my theory on the signal range bears out. For the sixth, we take our time and see what we can uncover,” Jeremiah said.

“The presented plan has merit, but current damage potential for Brewster is approaching catastrophic levels.” Dispatch’s voice came to their ears without prompting. It was easy to forget that, while she usually replied

only when addressed, Dispatch was technically listening to everything one said while wearing a comm. That was how she knew every detail of a battle without Heroes having to constantly check in.

“Jeremiah, I can only allow approximately half an hour for you to test your plan. Currently, evacuations of areas near the large robots are being undertaken, but there are too many of the smaller models to be allowed to spread. They must be taken out while they are centralized. Right now, we are saving as many civilians as possible. If you can neutralize the small units by stopping the large ones before evacuation is complete, I can allot more time. If you cannot, then all Manhattan-level Heroes will receive authorization to terminate the army.”

Not for the first time, Owen was glad he’d never tried to go into the DVA like some of the other retired Heroes. The call to wipe out entire city blocks wasn’t necessarily a wrong one, as those robots could do a lot more damage if they spread out. Still, there was no way to completely evacuate this much of the city, no matter how many Supers the DVA pulled in. Casualties were going to be inevitable, but it might be less than what the city would face if it became overrun with robots. There were no perfect calls, only ones that might minimize the damage.

“Understood, Dispatch.” Jeremiah licked his lips as he stared at the mech, eyes taking in every facet and weakness it presented. “Our best bet is probably to focus fire on one of them, show proof of concept. Once we know that destroying the large ones knocks out the smaller bots, we can shift to just taking out the big boys.”

“We don’t have long, so tell me where I’ll do the most good,” Owen said.

“There is one more item for Titan,” Dispatch continued, breaking into the short silence they presented. “You requested to be kept abreast of your team. They were, unfortunately, in the landing zone of another of the six giant robots. From what I’ve been able to track, it seems Hexcellent is injured, and they are still attempting to reach the Mordent building.”

The ground beneath Owen shattered. He looked down, expecting attack, only to realize that he’d shifted his weight without holding back. A second’s loss of focus and the world around him crumbled. “Dispatch, how are their chances? Do they have a clear path?”

“They are near the central point where more of the smaller units are

swarming. Even if we could spare evacuation personnel, their situation is too dangerous. I'm sorry, but they have very small, almost negligible, odds of surviving."

Owen's eyes swept around to Jeremiah, who nearly jumped back at the ferocity on Owen's face. "I need to go. I—"

"I know. Dispatch had me patched in, too."

"Can you manage without me?"

"Can I manage? Titan, look around; there are dozens of Heroes for me to work with. I can still easily make this happen. In fact, I'll do you one better. Dispatch, have Gale join Titan and me," Jeremiah said.

Moments later, the wind-manipulator settled to the ground a few feet away, glancing back and forth between Owen and Jeremiah. "What do you need?"

"I need you to take Titan to his team," Jeremiah told her. "Dispatch can give you the coordinates, but time is of the essence."

"I'm sorry; did you just ask me to play taxi while there's a giant robot a block away tearing up my town?" The wind seemed to pick up as Gale spoke, swirling around them in a not-so-subtly threatening manner.

"No, I'm asking you to help me diversify our efforts." Jeremiah pointed to the mech under all-out assault from the other Heroes. "We need to kill one of these things, and soon. But there's always the chance that the one we got is a lot stronger than the others, or has a secondary relay. It's the one that was dropped on the Heroes; we need to assume that wasn't an accident. Titan's team is right on top of another one, farther into Brewster, possibly under attack from it. Now, Titan, what are you going to do if you come upon one of these things trying to kill your team?"

"I'll kill the son of a bitch first," Owen said without hesitation.

"Exactly. So, if I'm going to split off two Heroes to try and topple one of the other big bots, I'd like it to be a pair that actually has a chance of succeeding: the leader of the strongest Hero group in Brewster and a living legend." Jeremiah patted both of them on their shoulders. "Can you think of any other duo with a better shot of pulling it off?"

"There might be others that are a better fit, but I can promise you there are none more motivated." Owen turned to Gale, whose skepticism was

beginning to melt. “Please, help me get there. I promise, I’m going to help keep your town safe.”

“I’ll do it, but I’m not so sure even the two of us can bring down one of those,” Gale said.

“If it’s attacking my team, it’s going down. *Trust me.*” For a moment, Owen was gone, all the gentle kindness and tempered power of a man who’d seen too much vanished. In his place was Titan, the Hero whose name was whispered among criminals like a demon’s curse, the man who no Super had managed to stop, who’d used his bare hands to rip apart many an allegedly unbeatable foe.

In that instant, Gale did trust him, and she felt a surge of pity for any who tried to get in his way.

“Just don’t get motion sick,” she warned. “I’m not the gentlest ride when I’m in a hurry.”

Things were going okay, until the building collapsed.

While their situation wasn't perfect, so far they'd managed to avoid being caught by any robots. Hexcellent had even started running under her own power as the worst of her headache finally began to ebb. However, avoiding being caught was not the same thing as avoiding detection, and as they ducked and veered between alleyways, the sounds of pursuit could always be heard at their backs. For possibly the first time since joining Mordent, every one of the team members were all simultaneously grateful to Mr. Greene; without his ridiculous exercise requirements, their stamina might have flagged out already. As it was, they were weary, but knowing they were only ten minutes or so from the potential safety of Mordent gave them all the energy needed to push through.

Then, unfortunately, a three-story building next to the alley they were in tipped forward, pushed by an unseen force on the other side. Bricks and debris began to rain, the only warning they got as the building started its descent.

Bubble Bubble reacted quickly; instead of throwing an orb around herself, she made a series of them overhead to create a sort of canopy to protect them as they ran. It wouldn't be enough to actually halt the building, which was already more splinters than structure, but it might let them make it to the other side. Zone was only a few feet ahead of her, not daring to leave the safety of her orb-canopy.

Galvanize, by virtue of being in the lead, was already clear of the collapsing obstacle. He had halted, ostensibly to wait for his team, and was gesturing at Bubble Bubble frantically. At first, she thought he wanted her to hurry, so that was what she did, manifesting more orbs in front of her as she ran, trying not to think about the toll that creating so many was taking. Already, her hands were starting to shake, but she pushed through. It was only when she got closer that Bubble Bubble realized Galvanize had been pointing past her to where she'd been running from. With a heart suddenly full of dread, Bubble Bubble looked over her shoulder.

Hexcellent, who'd been only a step or two behind her when the collapse started, was all the way back on the far side of the building, standing



next to Huggles. Maybe she had tripped, maybe the fatigue had gotten the better of her; whatever the reason, she'd been separated. In the chaos of trying to outrun a falling building, neither Bubble Bubble nor Zone had noticed.

Bubble Bubble slowed and turned to try and head back, but even from this distance she could see Hexcellent shaking her head. It was too late, and they both knew it. If Bubble Bubble went back now, she'd get caught in the collapse, already there was too much debris raining down to deflect. There was a chance that she could put an orb around herself to survive it, but the shaking in her hands was getting worse. She'd already drained too much of herself. Even if she did survive, what good would it do? By the time Bubble Bubble got out, the others would be long gone, either safe or. . . caught.

There was no way to save her friend. Hexcellent was clear of the building, but they'd all heard the robots getting closer. She was trapped, and it would be a matter of minutes until they caught up to her.

"Fuck that." Bubble Bubble turned back around and ran toward Galvanize again, Zone right beside her. Maybe she couldn't go back for Hexcellent, but that didn't mean she had to stand around and let her friend die. She would get out of here, double back down the next block, and reunite with the team summoner. Hexcellent had Huggles; she could survive for a little while, even against the robots. Hexcellent was tough. She could do it. She had to, or Bubble Bubble would never forgive herself.

Unfortunately, they made it no further than the mouth of the alleyway before the massive shadow fell across them.

\* \* \*

It was bittersweet, watching her friends run to safety even as the sounds of robots drew closer by the second. Hexcellent wanted to see them make it. It was her own fault that she'd stepped into a pile of loose rubble and gotten her foot stuck. If she'd called out, they would have waited, helped her get free, and turned the delay into five seconds rather than ten. But she hadn't. She'd stupidly tried to struggle free on her own instead of counting on the people around her, and it had cost her a chance at safe passage. That was *her* mistake, though. She'd be damned if she let Bubble Bubble try and pay the price for her, which was why Hexcellent waved her off. It would be a comforting thought in the end, she hoped, to at least know her friends made it out safely.

Heavy steps in the center of the alley revealed three robots, each built

like the ones she'd seen from footage shot during the previous attacks. Their eyes glowed as they assessed her, though the sword-armed demon a few feet closer naturally drew more attention. There was no need for blustering. The situation had its entire context laid out before them: kill or be killed.

"Slice 'em up, Huggles."

The demon lunged forward, taking a wide swing with both of her arms. The robots stepped nimbly aside, but Huggles was faster than she looked and pressed the attack. One of those arms made it through the torso of a robot. Hexcellent was about to let out a whoop of joy; however, it morphed into a cry of pain midway up her throat as the other two robots used the opportunity to forcibly tear Huggles' head from her shoulders until she dissolved back to smoke.

As she released a dull, half-choked whimper, Hexcellent fell hard to the ground. In comparison to the pain in her head, the impact barely registered. Her vision was nothing but static and spots, and she was pretty sure blood was pouring from her nose. Every nerve in her body felt like it was on fire. She tried to take refuge in the fact that the pain probably wouldn't last too long. After all, she was about to die.

Despite what she'd expected, that thought provided no comfort at all; it only made things worse. She didn't want the pain to end. She didn't want to die. She wasn't done yet, wasn't ready to walk out of the world. How many years had she pissed away? And only now, when things were getting good, was she going to get killed. It sucked. Hexcellent tried to get angry, to force herself to rise from the ground and die on her feet. All she managed was to tilt her head slightly upward, gaining a view of the approaching mechanical legs.

As fury failed her, fear set in. This was it. There was no last rally in her, and the Heroes were scattered. This was how she died. She wished Spyda was here, to whisper kindly with his poorly hidden accent. Or her team, to remind her that she'd managed to make a few friends in the world. Or Titan, though of course if he were here she wouldn't actually be in danger, now would she? But they weren't. Hexcellent. . . no, Hannah. . . was going to die alone, in the streets of Brewster, and that was what scared her most of all.

The fear stripped away her mental armor, all the defensiveness and walls she'd spent a lifetime building. As she curled up on the concrete, waiting for the end to come, she felt the terror wash over her in a way she hadn't since childhood. She wasn't a corpie or a Super: she was just a helpless person, afraid of the approaching unknown, the coming darkness, wishing

with all her might there was at least someone else there to hold her hand.

Somewhere, in the deepest part of her mind, a familiar presence not felt in decades stirred.

Hexcellent's body spasmed, something like a seizure causing her to convulse violently. Her consciousness slipped away—a mercy as this finally separated her from the pain, which was growing even more intense. Above her, the robots stared at the sudden thrashing, unsure of what to make of it. They were so focused on her, in fact, that neither saw the massive, furry, elongated foot as it slammed down on top of them, grinding both to scraps.

A soft paw reached down from the sky, delicately scooping Hexcellent's battered, but not yet broken, body into its grip. Though still unconscious, she nuzzled into the fur, and let out a small, peaceful sigh.

“What in the fucking hell is that?”

Owen followed the direction of Gale’s pointing hand, squinting to see through the wind. His jaw dropped. Years spent as a Hero, dealing with Supers of every manner, had exposed him to many a strange situation. He’d seen the rules of reality twisted, if not outright defied, in more ways than he could have imagined back when he started.

He had not, however, previously come across a twenty-story-tall bunny rabbit, standing on its hind legs, wearing a suit of medieval armor and breathing fire on the cluster of robots trying to attack it. As a few tried to run from the flames, it. . . well. . . hopped forward, smashing them and a large chunk of the street into oblivion. Owen took some comfort in knowing that it was apparently on their side, or at least that it hated robots.

“Please tell me that’s some Hero I somehow missed in my research of Brewster,” Owen said.

“Pretty sure I’d remember someone like that,” Gale replied. “By the looks of it, the smart money is either on shifter, summoner, or tech-genius creation.”

“That shift would take hours, if not days, to get in and out of. Tech-genius maybe, but we’ve been on watch for that sort of stuff, so I can’t believe we’d miss it. As for summoner, I don’t know of any who can pull in something that big. Plus, combat bunny? Who. . .” Owen’s words trailed off as he remembered the night that he and the team sat around sharing embarrassing stories. Hexcellent had told them about her childhood bunny, but said she couldn’t call him anymore. Granted, she hadn’t described him as able to step over buildings, yet Owen’s gut still screamed that the coincidence was just a little too much.

“Gale, can you sweep the area and get me coordinates on the big robot near my team? I need a few minutes here.”

“Are you going to fight the rabbit? Because even for you, that’s a pretty big one,” Gale pointed out.

“I really hope not,” Owen said. “But I may have just found one of my

team. I need to check on her. And, if things go well, I might even get us a helping paw.”

“Booooooooooooo,” Gale jeered. “Fine, but I’m giving you the quick drop, and I’m coming back as soon as I find our target.”

“Wouldn’t have it any other way.”

Owen barely got the words out before a blast of wind sent him hurdling forward. He ripped through the air before slamming to the ground fifty feet in front of the massive rabbit. Its ears twitched and it turned to face him, those beady black eyes gazing down at the sudden new arrival. They weren’t natural looking, more like they’d been based on someone’s toy stuffed rabbit than one with actual eyes. It had the dual impact of being disturbing and reassuring, as Owen felt like his hunch might be on the money.

“Hopcules, I hope?” Owen cupped his hands and yelled, in case the ears were just for show.

The rabbit, only watching him before, turned further, giving him its full attention. Slowly, the creature leaned forward. Owen could actually feel the hot breath from its pink nose despite the distance between them. If this really was a summon, then it was incredible. To create something this big, this capable of independent action, surely put whoever made it among the top one percent of all known summoners. Even better, if it was still standing, then its creator had to be alive.

“I’m a friend of Hexcellent’s,” Owen yelled. Talking to a rabbit was a bit odd, though given its size and armor, perhaps it shouldn’t have been. “I wanted to make sure she was safe.”

Hopcules peered at him warily. Owen had no idea how much it knew about Hexcellent or her life; he just had to hope that as long as she trusted him, it would be enough for the bunny. Moving in closer, the nose sniffed him twice. Evidently, this satisfied some unknown test, and it held up its right paw, uncurling its fingers, which Owen was certain real rabbits didn’t have, to reveal the battered but breathing body of Hexcellent.

On instinct, Owen took a step forward, and immediately the paw closed. He started to protest, then thought better of it. What was he going to try that the rabbit wasn’t already doing? Owen wasn’t a healer; he couldn’t fix her wounds. And he’d have to protect her from the robots flooding the city while she was unconscious. Confident as Owen was in his abilities, even he could concede that a giant fire-breathing monster who knew only loyalty

might be better suited to the task.

“I’m going to come back with a healer,” Owen yelled. He didn’t know if Hopcules understood what a healer was, or if the rabbit even had a grasp of the English language, but so far their communication had been going well. Besides, he didn’t have a lot of other options. “Someone to make Hexcellent better. Keep her safe until then.”

Hopcules snorted, and Owen had to wonder if an imaginary bunny was annoyed with him for trying to tell it to do what it had already planned. That thought alone made him really want a beer, but as Hopcules pulled back up to a standing position, turning to the new robots that had begun to pour into the area, Owen also felt a sense of relief. One member of his team, at least, was safe.

“Dispatch, this is Titan. We’ve got a giant summon shaped like a rabbit that’s probably hitting a few people’s radars. Let them know it’s friendly, and anyone who attacks it without cause will personally answer to me when this is over. If you can get me a healer to the location, we might be able to start using it as a more precise resource.”

“A healer? Is the rabbit injured?” If Dispatch felt at all odd asking such a question, it didn’t come through. Much as Owen wanted to chalk it up to her usual demeanor, the truth of the matter was that this probably didn’t even register on her weirdness scale. After all, she was in the ear of every Hero across the country. There was no telling what manner of crazy shit she’d witnessed.

“The rabbit is fine. Its summoner is in bad shape, though. All it’s doing right now is keeping her safe. Once she’s conscious again, she can give some proper orders.”

“Titan, please repeat. Did you just say that the summoner who called forth that thing is *unconscious*?” This time, he did hear the shock in her voice, and it only took a second to realize why. Usually summons disappeared when their creators went down. They were, after all, manifestations of their creator’s thoughts. When the thoughts ended, so did the summons. At least, that’s how it generally went. Every Super was different, after all.

“Confirmed, summoner is out, and the rabbit remains,” Owen told her. “So, maybe double time on that healer.”

“Resources are tight, but I’ll see what I can do,” Dispatch assured him. “Also, Gale has requested a direct connection to your comm.”

“I accept,” Owen said, and seconds later Gale’s voice came blasting in his ear.

“Titan! Jump as high as you can right now. I’m en route, but there’s no time to waste landing. I found the big bot and your team, which are in the exact same place. We’ve got maybe a minute or two before they’re in deep, and I can’t fight one of those on my own. They need our help, *now*.”

Without pause, Owen pushed off so hard that the ground buckled under his power as he went flying upward. Nearby, he could see Hopcules smashing apart every robot that came near it. Personally, Owen had always thought dogs to be the best of all pets.

But he was beginning to see the appeal of rabbits.

If having to (they hoped momentarily) leave Hexcellent wasn't bad enough—which it certainly was—the Mordent team found as soon as they emerged that they weren't the only ones moving. The giant mech was also making progress, though it had gone through structures rather than darting around them like the Supers. It had been what caused the collapse, no doubt; it seemed to be chasing a few people that were trying to escape from its sight. The only actual upside of walking into the mech's shadow was that there was so much chaos, a few people in costumes didn't draw much attention.

"Fuck me," Zone muttered, gazing up at the machine with wide-eyed terror. Galvanize grabbed his shoulder and jerked him forward, snapping the shirtless man out of his trance.

"Come on! We either run or die, and my legs can still move." Even as the words left his mouth, Galvanize knew how hollow they were. The street before them was sheer madness with the smaller robots swarming across the ground. Add in that the way behind them was blocked and that the giant bot could easily reach them with one step of its insect-like legs, their chances of surviving the next few minutes were looking slim. But Galvanize had faced death before. Not every rescue they went into was without risk, and he refused to let death take him standing still. Whether by crushing legs or a murderous robot, death would have to at least catch them.

They raced along the fractured city streets, trying to take cover by nearby buildings. All thoughts of direction were gone from their minds; Mordent was no longer their goal. Now, all they cared about was surviving from one footstep to the next. They picked their paths strategically, minimizing their contact with the robots whenever possible. It was a game of numbers, one that was quickly turning against them. More and more of the smaller units seem to rain down from the sky, and the places to hide were quickly running out. Something gigantic could be heard stomping around a few blocks away, which they all took to mean another mech was in the area. It was a bad scene and only getting worse.

Then, almost as if a beam of light from the heavens shone down to show him the way, Galvanize spotted something that gave him hope. A small alley, its entrance almost completely obscured from view, which would take them in the opposite direction of the robot hordes. It might even give them a



chance to circle back for Hexcellent, if luck was on their side. . . and since they would have to race all the way around the giant mech to reach the exit, luck would pretty much have to be.

Silently, he tapped Bubble Bubble and Zone on their arms and pointed to the alley down the street. It was hard to see, as the giant mech's legs blocked out so much of the view, but eventually they realized what he was showing them.

"We'll never make that," Bubble Bubble told him. "There are too many small robots on the periphery. We're barely hiding from them as it is; if we try and go all the way around we'll be caught for sure."

"Probably so, but we still have to try," Galvanize said.

"What if we went under it?" Zone motioned to the ample space between the robot's legs. One could drive a bus under there and still have ample clearance, so it wasn't an issue of space. But Galvanize couldn't imagine that the area was undefended, not on a machine built for such destructive ends.

"It's probably more dangerous underneath," Galvanize speculated.

"Seeing as the edges are definitely going to get us killed, I'm weirdly okay with 'probably more dangerous,'" Bubble Bubble said. "Whatever we do, let's just do it soon. Time is against us."

Despite all the preparation and training that PEERS teams had to undergo, the decisions that resulted in life or death often happened in split seconds. Galvanize knew they had to move and the alley might be their one shot at living. His team was right; the long way was basically a guaranteed death. Risky as running under a giant killer robot might be, it was the better choice.

Of course, that didn't mean either choice was actually going to keep them alive, but Galvanize shoved that thought out of his mind as he raced forward, motioning for the others to follow. They sprinted in the one direction no one else was going: toward a mech currently knocking down entire buildings.

It struck Galvanize that the world seemed to go curiously quiet as they ran between two of the six metal legs. All the madness that had been filling their ears was somewhat blocked by the impossibly big structure around them. It was peaceful, though not in a way that brought him comfort. No, this

peaceful was like that of a cemetery, or a watery cave left unexplored for centuries. It spoke of darkness buried just beneath the surface, waiting for a chance to arise once more.

That chance didn't take long to surface. They were no more than ten feet along in their journey when Galvanize caught sight of a red glow in the corner of his eyes. No time to think: another split second decision that might cost him, or his team, their lives.

"To the side!" Galvanize yelled, leaping away from where he'd been standing moments before a searing beam of energy struck the concrete. Bubble Bubble and Zone had moved on his orders and managed to avoid the shots coming at them as well. However, now that he'd stopped, Galvanize looked up to the source of the attacks and felt his heart drop.

All along the underside of the robot were at least two dozen glowing red circles, each of which could roast him and his team alive. Another three fired, but before they could hit, a wall of blue energy appeared in front of them.

Bubble Bubble was stooped down, arms held out as she focused on keeping the orb around them in place. With every shot that landed, her body seemed to shake. Maybe if the day had just begun, she might have been able to keep it up for a while, but as it stood, Galvanize knew she was only buying them a few extra seconds. Maybe a minute, tops.

Galvanize wracked his brain, trying to think of something, anything he could do to get them out of there. He considered Zone's abilities, Bubble Bubble's power, and what he could augment. But no matter how he turned their situation around in his head, nothing provided even a glimmer of hope. They just weren't strong enough. Each of them might be Supers, but this was the sort of situation even Heroes would have trouble with, and none of them had power on that level.

Galvanize had been determined to at least die trying, and now it seemed that was exactly what they were going to do.

"Getting. . . tired. . ." More and more beams were locking on to them. Bubble Bubble seemed to be fading. Their time was almost up. All that remained were the few precious seconds she'd bought them, so Galvanize decided to make use of her gift.

"Zone, Bubble Bubble, I just want you to know how proud I am of both of you, and of all we've accomplished as a team. No matter what

happens next, try to take comfort in the fact that we are among the few who can say we left this world better than we found it.”

Bubble Bubble’s arms fell, and the orb around them flickered out of existence. Galvanize, all his bravery spent on surviving this long, closed his eyes. He’d done enough; staring down a firing squad wasn’t the way he wanted to go.

Instead of hot, searing pain ripping apart his body, however, Galvanize felt a tremendous blast of wind strike and send him spinning roughly through the air. When he finally landed and managed to pull his eyelids apart, he was no longer trapped beneath the robot.

Instead, Gale was staring at him, at his whole team, who were miraculously unhurt. She floated above them, lit by the afternoon sun which they could once again see. Her wind had blown them some distance from the mech, which seemed to be distracted.

“About time you dropped that shield,” Gale said. “I’ve been trying to get you out for the past thirty seconds. Titan, your people are clear. Time to step it up.”

“Titan is here?” Bubble Bubble asked, turning her head in a vain effort to find their Hero Liaison.

“Sure is, who do you think kept that thing distracted?” Gale asked. “But now that you’re out, he’s going to stop playing so nice. And as soon as I get you three a little higher and safer, I’m going to help.”

“Wait!” Galvanize yelled. “Hexcellent needs your help more; she got trapped a few blocks behind us.”

Gale merely smiled as a new gust of wind began to lift them up from the ground. “Hexcellent is probably the best off of anyone here. Don’t worry, you’ll definitely see it from the rooftops.”

“Titan, your people are clear.”

Owen’s whole body tingled with relief at those words, aided a bit perhaps by the energy blast one of the robots nearby was trying to kill him with. It had been hard, letting Gale be the one to go save them, trusting her to make sure they survived, but part of being a Hero was accepting that no one was the best at everything. For rapid extraction, Gale’s abilities were better suited than his, and he was certainly the superior choice for a distraction. Still, ever since she’d left his sight and he’d begun ripping up robots and throwing them at the big mech, his heart had been filled with worry that something would go wrong. He’d already failed so many people who depended on him throughout his life. Losing his team might be one blow too many.

But that hadn’t happened. Gale had gotten them clear and was likely lifting them somewhere safe before she rejoined the battle. Owen grabbed another robot and shredded it into two pieces, then hurled both at the mech. His projectiles weren’t doing any real damage, but he was definitely holding the thing’s attention, drawing occasional rounds of bullets and energy, neither of which caused Owen to so much as stumble.

“Dispatch, what’s the situation with civilians around me?”

“This area was a business district that began evacuations during the first wave of attack,” Dispatch told him. “The last stragglers were seen fleeing several minutes prior, though not all were successful. By current accounts, the area is considered fully evacuated.”

“Glad to hear it. And my clearance for property?”

“The DVA has ruled that if Jeremiah’s theory proves true, targeting the large robots would be far more prudent than fully unleashing Manhattan-level Heroes. They want to see a big one brought dropped as soon as possible, and with the civilians gone, you are in one of the best positions. Clearance is Full Demolition: do what’s necessary to bring your target down,” Dispatch instructed.

“Understood. I’ll still try to minimize where I can.” It wasn’t always possible to get DVA clearances in the heat of battle, but for a fight this big, Owen knew damn well doing so would make things easier. There was going

to be a lot of cleanup and insurance claims when this was all said and done, and the last thing he needed was to be held for reckless destruction. But now they'd given him their blessing, and he knew the area was as clear as possible.

He could finally get down to work.

"You know, I've had to fight robots before. Not this many or this often, but your kind pops up from time to time when some smart Super wants a machine to do their dirty work." Owen grabbed a pair of the robots that were trying to attack and crushed them in his hands, scattering their debris as he moved forward. Another came at him; seconds later it was in pieces. With no other Heroes or civilians around, he didn't have to worry about where the hurled shrapnel might land.

"Personally, I'm not really a fan. I prefer opponents who can think on their feet and maybe use enough wisdom to give up when they know the fight is unwinnable."

This time, five of them ran for him. Owen met them head on. The things were strong, no doubt about it, but Owen had fought stronger, and that was all it took. Raise the bar once and that's where it lived forever on. His power was a brutish, simple one that paled in comparison to some of the more grandiose out there, but it *was* effective. In seconds, the five robots were pieces in his wake, and the large mech was only a few feet away.

"There is one good thing about dealing with robots, though. Especially ones as big as you. It's probably the only time I get to have a fight where I don't need to hold back. And I have to say, from time to time, that is an absolute pleasure."

The mech turned to launch another pointless barrage of projectiles at him, but Owen was no longer there. He'd leapt into the air, turning the ground below him into utter rubble as he soared upward. His course was the center of the mech's torso, but as he'd expected, it wasn't going to let him land so easily. One of the four arms swept through the air, intent on smacking Owen back to the ground. Instead, he grabbed on as it struck, his fingers bending the metal as he pulled himself up, getting into position just above where the massive gun joined to its wrist.

"You big guys always seem tough, but beating you is just about knowing the simple trick. It's the same way you eat a whale. One bite at a time, you bastard." He reared back, spreading out his palm to get as wide a surface area as possible, then slammed his hand through the metal wrist. It

took several more blows, but eventually the wrist was so shattered that the entire gun broke away, smashing to the ground and flattening a few robots in the process.

Owen looked up at the six-eyed head. He was pretty sure at least a few of those orbs were gazing angrily at him. If the thing was pissed now, it would be livid by the time he was finished.

He began to climb up the remaining section of arm, slowly making his way closer to the torso. A loud whooshing sound ripped through the air, and suddenly Owen found himself and the arm he was holding in free fall. They crashed heavily on to the street, and before he could react, one of the six legs was above him and dropping fast, clearly intent on crushing him like a bug.

“Detaching parts, pretty clever,” Owen admitted as he rolled out of the way. “But you’ll run out of arms eventually.” The leg kept pace with his movements, and as he pushed off the ground, it slammed into his back, pinning him to the concrete below.

“Holy shit, are you okay?” Gale’s voice came through his comm, and even though he couldn’t see where she was at the moment, she obviously had line of sight on him.

“Been better,” Owen admitted, his voice a bit strained. “But I’m pretty sure the gravity thingie they put in these to make them light enough to function reduced its weight. Normally I’d expect this to be a lot worse.”

“Normally? One day we need to have a talk about what you consider normal,” Gale said. “Can you get out?”

“Not easily. I’m strong enough to move, but with this much weight, if I try to shove off the ground my arms will probably go right through it, especially given how much we’ve wrecked the street. Little help?”

“Pretty sure I can hit it hard enough to knock it aside, but you’ll need to scramble,” Gale warned.

“Even a second is plenty. I just have to flip over. Then I can grab the damn leg and start tearing it apart.”

“Yeah, I heard your whole ‘one bite at a time’ spiel. Personally, if I had to kill a whale, I think I’d rather a harpoon to the heart.” Even as she spoke, Owen could hear the wind picking up around her. He mentally readied himself for the impending attack.

“Those arms are quick, they’ll knock me aside if I do a direct run,” Owen told her.

“In a hurricane, winds blow so fast that pencils get embedded in trees. I’m pretty sure I can get you past a few waving arms. Now get ready: that leg is about to move.”

“If you can do it, I’m in.” Owen barely got the words out when a tremendous blast of wind deafened him. It struck the leg at one of its joints and bent it outward. The pressure on Owen vanished. He pushed himself forward, getting on his feet before the leg could pin him again. He’d made it all of ten steps before another blast of wind hit him in the back, lifting him skyward at a rapidly increasing speed.

“Pretend you’re doing a cannonball off the high-dive,” Gale instructed, yelling to be heard over the comms. “Tuck everything in and prepare for impact. As of now I’m Captain Ahab, except we’re killing our damned whale.”

It had been a long time since Owen was in a real fight. Picking off stray robots here and there didn't exactly test his limits, and while the work with his team was rewarding, it usually demanded more effort to keep control than to push himself. The assessment with Elemental Fury was the nearest he'd come, and even that was closer to a dance than a brawl since he had to evade and subdue without seriously injuring. He'd been so long outside of a true battle that he'd almost forgotten the thrill of danger and adrenaline that coursed through one's system.

That familiar feeling came rushing back as he tore through the air, moving so fast that he couldn't even see the giant mech's arms as it reached uselessly for him. Gale had built up too much speed for the thing to have a shot in hell.

Owen roared past all its defenses and slammed directly into its chest. Were he human, or even less-established in his career, Owen would have been a smear on the metal surface. Instead, he left a sizable dent and merely shook his head, more dizzy from the ride than hurt from the stop.

Already he could see the remaining arms reaching for him, so Owen didn't waste the time he had. Bending the metal under his fingers to get a solid grip, he reared back and punched directly into the dent he'd made. Unlike when fighting the robot's arm, this time he tried to concentrate the force as much as possible. His fist effortlessly broke through the armored barrier. Grabbing both sides of the hole, he tore it wider and then tumbled through, only a few feet ahead of the metal appendages trying to knock him away.

Truthfully, he hadn't been entirely sure what to expect once he was inside. Robots might be semi-regular occurrences in the Hero world, but the giant type weren't exactly run-of-the-mill. Part of him expected the cavity within to be filled with the smaller bots operating the big mech like some sort of weird puppet. Instead, it seemed like he'd just thrown himself into a gigantic car engine. All around him were motors, pistons, and wires so tightly bunched together that he could barely move without bumping into something.

Owen was a little disappointed, actually. Silly as it might have been, he would have loved to have seen the puppet theory in action. On the upside,



however, this made his job a whole lot easier. He didn't know how these things worked or what critical parts would take it down, so Owen was just going to break everything, which was much easier, especially when it was all neatly packed in like this.

Setting his sights on the nearest cluster of moving metal beams, Owen braced himself and threw a punch that he hoped would be just strong enough to send the heavier bits bouncing around inside the armored torso.

\* \* \*

No one was sure exactly what came bursting out of the mech's back like buckshot, flying into the air before they could make out so much as a blurry detail, but the PEERS team had a pretty good idea of what had caused it. After all, witnessing Gale fling Titan into the giant robot's chest had significantly narrowed down the need for conjecture.

Despite the large crater in its front and smoking holes in its back, the mech continued moving about, seemingly unbothered by the Hero currently tearing up its insides. More of the smaller bots were still pouring out, though they seemed to slow significantly. Whether it was running out of steam or keeping the bots inside to fight the intruder was anyone's guess, though the latter strategy seemed like it would be pretty inefficient.

"Just like the good old days." The voice came from the rooftop's edge where a man wearing a familiar Hero costume was climbing up from the fire escape. "I mean, not the giant robot part. Tech wasn't quite as fancy as it is these days so they never got them that big. But dropping Titan into the middle of a fray and letting him do his work, now that takes me back."

"A pleasure to see you again, Topsy," Galvanize greeted him. "What brings you to our rooftop?"

"Heard Titan's people were in need of a little help, and seeing as I'm technically just supposed to be a coach anyway, it seemed like a good place for me to lend a hand," Topsy replied. "Besides, Titan looked out for my team; least I could do is watch over his. Seems like it might have been unnecessary, though."

"No, this is perfect," Bubble Bubble said. "You can go help him! Gale just threw him inside the mech without joining. Even for Titan, that has to be dangerous. If you hurry, you two can bring that thing down before he gets hurt."

“The concern is touching, but misplaced,” Topsy assured her. “Do you ever wonder why he’s called Titan?”

From the battlefield nearby, a huge metal beam suddenly burst out of the mech’s lower torso and was dragged upward, like an inverted stabbing. The behemoth’s legs began to shake, no longer capable of making the smooth, controlled motions that it had previously. Slightly higher, a blast of wind shattered another of its eyes, the third one taken out since Gale began her outer assault.

“Because he’s really strong, like Titans from mythology,” Zone said.

“That’s probably why Titan agreed to use the name, but I actually know the Hero who suggested it to him, and that wasn’t the reason.” Topsy paused to glance over the edge of the roof, taking in the shuddering robot with a dark smile. “That fellow was Titan’s rival back in their HCP days, and when they first started out he was much more powerful than our friend currently killing a robot from the inside. But every time he lost, Titan kept coming back, stronger and more determined than before. He just couldn’t be stopped.”

Suddenly, the mech’s legs gave out. It came crashing to the ground, the weight of its body clearly no longer being offset by a gravitational anomaly. The arms flailed, now too heavy to move properly, and smoke poured out from the holes in its torso.

“You can never really kill a Titan,” Topsy said, nodding to the fallen monster that only moments ago had seemed so indomitable. “Even the gods could only imprison them. That’s why the name was suggested. Because if you’ve ever seen him in a real battle, walking through blood and fire completely unstained, you understand what it is to witness something that’s truly unstoppable. The man you’ve been working with all this time is a good fellow, but he isn’t the real Titan. Titan is a destroyer, a force of nature, a monster that only the grace of God has put on our side.”

Topsy raised his hand and pointed to the collapsing mech. Flames began to rise out from the many openings punched in the giant body. Around it, the smaller robots suddenly began to twitch, then collapse, like puppets whose strings had been cut. After one last outward explosion from the place where the torso joined to the metal legs, a figure could be seen walking out from within the mechanical beast’s belly. Even from so far away they could recognize the familiar red and blue costume as the man strolled, dirty and sooty but unharmed, away from his fallen foe.

“*That* is the real Titan. And as an over-the-hill Hero who’s witnessed too much evil in his lifetime, I can’t tell you how fucking ecstatic I am to see him again.”

## 111.

The first thing Hexcellent noticed as her eyes fluttered open was the strange man wearing a red and white costume with his fingers on her forehead. The second was Titan, standing over the other man's shoulder and looking anxious. The third, a realization that quickly dwarfed the other two, was that she was lying in the paw/hand of a massive rabbit, which was stooped over to allow Titan and the stranger access. Surprisingly, it wasn't panic that welled in her at the sight of the towering creature, but relief, like something long trapped had finally gotten free.

"Is this. . . Hopcules?"

It nodded, a gigantic gesture that was impossible to miss, staring down at her with those black shiny eyes. He looked much the same as he had when she was a child, armored and human-like, but easy to cuddle. She wondered if he could still cast light from his mouth, like he did when something in her room had made a noise and he lit it up to show her nothing was there. It was possible, though clearly things had changed.

Slowly, Hexcellent pulled herself to a reclined lean, noticing for the first time Galvanize, Zone, and Bubble Bubble were also there, albeit standing farther back from the giant bunny. Next to her team stood Gale and an older Hero that she half-recognized as Titan's friend. Around them were dozens, if not hundreds of the robots, all collapsed lifeless on the ground. There was also a fair amount of damage to the nearby buildings, some in the shape of giant rabbit-like footprints.

"Oh fuck me running. Am I going to be held liable for all this? 'Cause if so, you can go ahead and just kill my ass now."

"Good job, Bedrest," Titan told the man in red and white. "Looks like she's back to her usual cranky self."

"She should still take it easy for a while; healing or not, that sort of damage takes a toll. I have to get going, though, lots of our people need patching up." Bedrest walked away from the paw and Hexcellent, over to where a nondescript man in a rumpled suit was standing. Seconds later they were gone, seemingly vanished into thin air.

"Okay, but seriously, how much of this is on me?" Hexcellent asked,

just before Titan wrapped her in a hug so tight that for a moment she worried Hopcules would have to intervene.

“You damn kids are going to give me a heart attack, and I don’t think I can even get those.” Titan slowly set her down, at which moment the rest of the team swarmed her. Hard as she tried to seem unbothered by the attention, it was impossible not to be a little moved by the influx of warmth.

“Anyway, to answer your question, you’re technically clear on all this,” Titan told her. “For one thing, it was self-defense, since Hopcules only attacked robots that came after it. Not to mention the fact that you were unconscious, so you had no say in what was happening. I ran everything up the ladder while we waited for Bedrest, and while there might be some hearings and paperwork, you’ll come out fine. I’ll make sure of it.”

Something about his voice made it clear that Titan meant those words, possibly by any means necessary. Hexcellent had a good idea of just how many means the man had. As the others finally let go of her, she turned around to take in Hopcules in all his glory.

“When I summoned him as a kid, he was like five feet tall, tops,” Hexcellent said.

“You said you summoned him to drive off your fears, right?” Bubble Bubble ventured. “Well, you’ve seen a lot more since then. Maybe you’ve got much bigger fears.”

“On the subject of your rabbit, I need to talk with you about something,” Titan interrupted. “We’ve learned that those giant robots are acting as relay points for the smaller ones. Basically, kill the big guys, and the little ones go limp.”

Something in Hexcellent’s brain wriggled again. Why did that seem familiar?

“Unfortunately, just like with the little ones, once the big bots are damaged to a certain point, they self-destruct everything we might be able to use, signal relays included. Currently, the Heroes have been able to take down four of the large mechs, and they’re dealing with the fifth right now,” Titan continued. “The sixth will be a special case, however. We’re going to try to infiltrate it, find the device that’s receiving and relaying the master signal, and trace it back to the source. Brewster can’t take another attack like this one; it needs to end today.”

“So do you need me to unsummon Hopcules to clear space or something?” Even as the words left her mouth, Hexcellent hated the taste of them. She’d just been reunited with an old friend; the last thing she wanted was to send him away again.

“Actually, pretty much the exact opposite.” Titan pointed up at the giant rabbit, who was still watching everything with those glassy eyes. “Your summon is incredible, and right now it might be the most useful piece on the battlefield. If you’re willing, we’d like to have you and Hopcules help contain the mech while a team hunts through its insides for the signal device. If the robot is fighting something of equal strength, that will keep it from tearing up the city, which will minimize damage and casualties while we take the time to search. It’s dangerous work, though, I won’t lie to you about that. I understand if you don’t want to take the risk, especially so soon after a close call.”

“Risk comes with the turf of being a PEERS,” Hexcellent replied. “But you’re sort of skipping over a big detail, aren’t you? Self-defense is one thing; what you’re describing sounds a lot more like picking a fight, and that’s Hero work. Giant bunny or no, I’m not a Hero, remember?”

“No, you’re not,” Titan agreed. “But this work is messy, and it’s far from the first time that a Super who had what we needed wasn’t wearing a mask. The DVA has protocol for this kind of situation, and with Brewster’s predicament, you weren’t hard to sell them on. The technical term is Temporarily Authorized Hero Asset, and it means you can fight the good fight until the current threat is neutralized.”

“And if I screw up?” Hexcellent had seen what happened to Heroes who made serious mistakes; the DVA wasn’t shy about letting the public watch the trials. It was important to show that these enhanced beings charged with people’s safety were held accountable. That was part of why people were comfortable trusting Heroes.

“Then that’s on me as the one that authorized you.” Titan set a hand on her shoulder, his massive palm almost engulfing her whole upper arm. “But you won’t screw up. If you decide to fight, I know you’re going to kick that thing’s ass.”

“And what makes you so certain?” Hexcellent shot back, wishing she had as much confidence as he did.

“Because I know you. Because I’ve seen you work. And because the

first time we trained together, your immediate instinct was to try and show up me, a Hero renowned for his strength.” Titan smiled down at her. “Half of this job is just having the guts to wade into dangerous, impossible situations and try to fight them back to salvageable. Guts are something you’ve got a lot of. Guts and a giant fire-breathing rabbit.”

“He breathes fire now?” Hexcellent glanced up at Hopcules, as if expecting an explanation, but only received the same endless stare looking back at her. Shit, she’d never given him eyelids, had she?

“Oh good, that’s news for you, too. We were wondering how that bunny didn’t burn your house down,” Zone said.

“He can do a hell of a lot, and so can you, but only if you want to.” Titan dug into his pocket and pulled out a small silver device. “This was dropped off along with your healer. It will connect you with all the other Heroes out there trying to save this city. Take it, and until that last mech is beaten, you’re one of us.”

Hexcellent reached out, her fingers with their chipped black nail polish wrapping around the device and carefully lifting it from Titan’s hand. The dream she’d had as a child, the one she’d pissed away with years of bad decisions, seemed to glow in the gizmo’s metallic depths. She was never going to be a real Hero, and she’d made peace with that a long time ago. But if she couldn’t grab hold of her dream, she would still settle for grazing her fingers against it.

“Tell me how this thing works, Titan. It sounds like we’ve got some robot ass to kick.”

“Hoooooly shiiiiit!”

Hexcellent’s scream was drowned out by the thunderous boom of Hopcules landing on the street below and launching himself upward once more, leaving only a giant footprint behind. She stood nestled between his neck and shoulder, while Titan and the rest of her team clung to the top of Hopcules’s armor a few feet away. Her words seemed to sum up everyone’s sentiment; there was no carnival ride in the world that could simulate riding on the shoulders of a giant rabbit as it hopped through town.

With no teleporter on hand capable of moving a twenty-story bunny, there was only one way to get to the final mech’s location. Several Heroes had already evacuated a path. Others were driving the mech toward them in an effort to minimize how much damage was done. Word came down from Dispatch, the strange woman relaying everything through the new comm Hexcellent had shoved in her ear, that they were converging on a spot that had already been halfway leveled fighting an earlier mech. Better to rebuild one section of town than two.

Nearby, Gale and Topsy floated alongside Hopcules, her powers keeping the two of them aloft. Though they’d been offered the chance to ride on the rabbit’s shoulder, the two Heroes had declined. Hexcellent wasn’t sure if it was out of pride or prudence, and she didn’t really care. They were free to miss out; all the more room for her and her team.

“Hexcellent, you’ve reached the rendezvous point.”

Dispatch’s voice brought her back to reality. She looked down and noticed a cluster of brightly-colored costumes dotting the ground. The Heroes that were waiting for them. For her. There was a moment as Hexcellent began to rise from Hopcules’s shoulder that she genuinely thought it was her joy lifting her up. Then she felt the swirling wind and realized that it was Gale transporting her team to the ground.

Even as she was losing altitude, Hexcellent could see the mech, which was only a few blocks away. It was moving slowly and steadily as the other Heroes drove it toward her. She wasn’t sure if it had noticed Hopcules or not, but as soon as she got the order, she’d make sure it couldn’t pay attention to anything else.



“You know, I have seen some crazy shit in my days. Really, truly insane stuff. And this doesn’t take the cake. . . but it’s still pretty impressive.”

The man speaking had his head tilted back as he took in Hopcules. Of all the people waiting for her, he looked the least like a Hero, wearing a simple outfit that was mostly notable for the large array of pockets. Eventually he turned from the bunny to the woman who summoned it, making his way over to Hexcellent and taking her hand.

“Pleasure to meet you, Hexcellent. I’m Jeremiah, and yes, that’s my Hero name. You probably recognize most of the group from the news, but I keep a lower profile.”

Jeremiah was right; as a Brewster resident, Hexcellent was quite familiar with Aether and Deadlift, to say nothing of Birdsmen, Spring, Granite, and Misdirection, the rest of Elemental Fury. There were other Heroes as well, ones she’d seen on the news in other towns, Heroes who didn’t call Brewster home. As she scanned them, another face caught her eye, one that lacked a mask yet was familiar all the same.

“Isn’t that the fucking disintegration guy? Why isn’t he in jail?”

“I have a name,” the man muttered. He was wearing a white jumpsuit, standard issue to mark Supers in prison, and rubbing his wrists where handcuff marks could still be seen. “It’s Eli, and I’m here for the same reason you are.”

“You can summon a giant fire-breathing rabbit?” Hexcellent asked.

“He’s here because he’s got a talent we need,” Titan explained, cutting off the conversation before it spiraled into a barrage of insults. “Jeremiah had him pulled out of jail to lend a hand in exchange for a reduced sentence. The armor on these mechs is tough, and Eli can get people in without having to punch through it.”

“But you *can* punch through it,” Hexcellent pointed out.

“Given the size of these things, having just one Hero search for the signal relay would take too long.” As Jeremiah spoke, he began pulling what looked like cell phones with extra wires attached from his pockets and handing them to the various Heroes. “One of my teammates whipped these up in the last hour; *hopefully* they’ll be able to find the device that’s receiving the master signal. We’re going to split up and cover as much ground inside the thing as possible. Aether and I will be paired up, so if anyone gets a hit on

their detector, contact us and I'll head over to jam in the tracking device."

Jeremiah paused in front of Titan, only a few of the boxes left in his hands. "Since we don't want to do so much damage inside that the mech melts down, I'd prefer to have our more. . . destructive. . . members help the rabbit keep it busy. You okay with taking distraction duty?"

"I was going to demand it," Titan replied. "No way in hell I'm leaving Hexcellent on her own."

"This is pretty fucking far from being on my own," she said, jerking a thumb at the bunny whose shadow was looming over all of them.

"Still, these big ones are tough. I'm watching your back, so make peace with it."

"Titan really fits in better in the line of fire anyway," Jeremiah seconded. "And hey, at least it will make for good footage." He nodded to a nearby rooftop, where a news crew could just be made out pointing their cameras over the side. Now that she was looking, Hexcellent caught sight of another crew a block away, and a few more a street over from them.

"Wow, that is ballsy," Hexcellent said.

Jeremiah clucked his tongue. "Not every Super goes into our line of work. They've probably all got a way to protect themselves or vanish if the need arises. Even if they don't, I'm not turning them away. After all this destruction, we'll need some good footage of the Heroes fighting back the threat."

"And one corpie." Bubble Bubble's voice wasn't particularly loud, but it still managed to catch the attention of everyone nearby.

"The term is Privately Employed Emergency Response Super," Gale corrected.

"God damn right it is," Titan agreed.

"And we are thankful to have her, but time is running short."

Jeremiah finished doling out the boxes and turned to address everyone, effortlessly commanding their attention. Part of Hexcellent wondered how she'd never heard of him before; between the good looks and leadership skills, it seemed like Jeremiah would have a bit of notoriety.

"When the mech arrives, everyone is either on hunting or containment

duty,” he continued. “You know your team by whether or not there’s a jerry-rigged phone in your hand. Gale, we need you to use Eli to erode the armor before coming in to join us so that there are plenty of easy entrances. Everyone else: get in, scan the equipment, and pray those damn things work. Those of you on the outside, contain the damage as much as possible, but try not to break the mech too bad. Remember, we’re going to be inside the thing; not to mention that if you bust it beyond a certain point, everything useful inside will self-destruct, signal relay included. Also watch out for the smaller bots. They’re sticking near it and we can’t shut them down until we trace the signal. Other than that, have fun, and maybe try to put on a good show. The cameras are watching.”

“Did he just actually tell us to have fun?” Hexcellent tried to keep her voice at a whisper only Titan and her team could hear, but from the snickers of a few nearby Heroes, it seemed to have carried farther than intended.

“Jeremiah is trying to keep the mood light. Going into battle tense doesn’t help anyone,” Titan told her. “Now, let’s have Gale get you back on the bunny before the mech arrives. People are going to be counting on you to guide Hopcules and buy time for the Heroes to do their work.”

“All while news cameras watch on, ready to judge every mistake I make. But no pressure, right?”

“Look at the upside,” Titan said. “If we make it through this, that rabbit is marketable as hell. You’ll have Hopcules plushies in stores by Christmas.”

As an agent and friend to a wide variety of Heroes, Lenny could have pulled any number of strings to be among the first people to be evacuated from Brewster. He hadn't bothered contacting any of his active Heroes, though, and instead called in a quick favor from a retired former client. The ones on duty had better things to do than worry about him. A quick teleport later and he was in his mountain home, a place he'd bought in hopes of spending time away from the job, focusing just on himself in the seclusion of nature.

The wide-screen television above the gas fireplace, wired up to a complete satellite package, betrayed his failure in disconnecting from the world. In fact, Lenny barely got any use from his cabin unless something threatened the town he was in and he needed a quick place to lie low. Sometimes he loaned it out to clients that needed to hide out from the press for a while as well. It was spacious enough to house four comfortably, or six in a pinch, and despite his intention of roughing it, Lenny had stocked the place with cushy furniture and high-end electronics, to say nothing of the booze. In a way, the cabin had served its purpose, though. He'd bought it for soul-searching, and what he'd uncovered was that he was not a man who wanted to disconnect from the job. He *was* the job, and he was happiest when he was knee-deep in it.

At the moment, he was juggling two phone calls, a half-dozen news streams on his laptop, and a live television feed of the fight in Brewster. The footage was grainy and far off, which was a damn shame; otherwise something like this would easily make the national reels for a week, minimum. Still, it was close enough that he could just make out the big robot being pushed through town, drawing nearer to another massive form with each step. The angle was shit; a skyscraper he didn't remember seeing before was blocking out everything save for the tips of a pair of ears. But Lenny was plugged in; he knew what was lurking behind the building, as well as how many of his clients were about to go take the last mech bastard on.

"Yeah, you heard me," Lenny snapped, his energy much higher than the weary clerk on the phone. "Ten thousand of the old Titan shirts. Well then, update the damn material, but keep the look as vintage as possible. Trust me, you're going to want to get ahead of this one."

A new figure appeared on screen just as the mech cleared the last row of buildings and approached the waiting ambush. It was huge by most scales, though compared to the robot it looked like a normal-sized bird. Lenny hadn't seen that one in quite a while. The screen shook as the news crew started moving, getting closer than was safe or prudent to the ensuing battle. Lenny hoped they stayed cautious, but he also hoped they didn't turn back. This was going to be solid gold.

"Go ahead and make sure all the Birdsmen merch is stocked up as well, especially his bird plushies. Looks like he's going to be getting some screen time, too."

\* \* \*

"Told you I had one more!" Birdsmen yelled the barb at Titan from atop his final summon, a stone-colored bird with at least a twenty-five-foot wingspan. The creature looked like a statue come to life. With every flap, rubble flew from its wings. Despite appearing as though it weighed somewhere in the ton region, it effortlessly climbed higher into the sky, moving closer to the mech. The robot turned to face the bird, giving Gale and Eli the chance to start disintegrating holes in its hull.

"Ranged distraction team, we are go! Get in there and draw fire." Jeremiah's voice echoed through the area; he barely even needed the comms to give orders. "All of our melee people—and this includes Hexcellent and Hopcules—you hold back until we're inside. We don't need to dodge your bunny while trying to break in."

"Yeah, about that, why isn't it already attacking us?" Hexcellent asked, her voice nervous but determined. Seeing as she was currently standing on Hopcules's shoulder, braced for whatever attack the mech might throw, it was a fair and relevant question.

"This is Misdirection; I was told to keep you hidden until it was show time." The illusion-wielding Hero walked over from the group to stand near Titan and Hopcules. "We thought it might attack something as big as you, and like Jeremiah said, that could be problematic while the Heroes are breaking in. Plus, this gives you the element of surprise."

"How in the hell did you hide something this big?" Hexcellent asked, beating Titan to the question by only a few seconds.

"I'm not on a team like Elemental Fury for nothing," Misdirection replied. "I conjured a fake skyscraper around you. Around most of us,

actually. As far as anyone more than fifty feet away can tell, this is just a building. Should let us keep the mech from knowing how much we're working with."

There was a crunch from behind, and Titan turned to find Granite standing nearby. Several feet farther away and he caught a glimpse of Galvanize, who was jogging over. "Our illusionist is top notch," Granite said. "With her, we never have to tip our hand on the battlefield."

"Mr. Granite," Galvanize said, breaking in. "Spring told me that you were looking-"

"Just Granite, and heck yeah I was looking for you. Heard you've been going around juicing everyone up, thought I might get in on that. I mean, I'm strong, but. . ." Granite nodded to the mech, which was currently being peppered with disintegration holes along with energy blasts from other Heroes while a dozen costumed figures raced to slip inside its torso. "That thing is probably stronger."

"I don't actually make you stronger, though," Galvanize explained. "I just bring you to the best you can possibly be."

"Still better than nothing," Granite said. "I have to be on top of my game, otherwise Birdsman and Roc-Steady are going to get all the attention."

"He named that thing Rocksteady?" Titan asked, momentarily dumbfounded.

"R-O-C, like the giant mythical bird. Also it's a pun since it's stone. And no, none of us has any idea how it can fly." Granite finished the explanation and looked at Galvanize, who simply took a step closer to the shifter currently composed of rocks and did what he'd been asked.

**"Do your best."**

Granite stiffened at the words then stretched his limbs carefully, testing their movements with the boost surging through him. "Not bad at all. I can tell I haven't broken any barriers, but I feel. . . good. Like I'm on top of my game. Titan, you getting in on this?"

"Eighty percent of the Heroes have infiltrated the mech's torso," Dispatch said, quietly speaking in their ears. "Melee distraction team, be ready. You'll be called as soon as the percentage passes ninety-five."

"Titan prefers to reach his pinnacle without help," Galvanize replied,

unaware of the orders being issued across the comms.

“Well, in rescue work, suddenly using more strength than I’d planned could be dangerous,” Titan replied. “I need near perfect control in those delicate situations.” He looked at the stomping mech, and then at Hexcellent all the way up at the top of her rabbit’s shoulder. As he turned, he also caught sight of a small group of reporters getting in for a closer view. Well, that would make Lenny happy, at least.

“But you know, seeing as I’m playing defense today anyway, a little extra pep in the step might not be such a bad idea.”

“Really?” It was one of the few times Titan had seen Galvanize truly taken aback, even his composed smile faltering with uncertainty. “Are you sure? I mean, you don’t actually need my boost. You’re plenty strong enough as it is.”

“No doubt about it.” Titan took Galvanize by the shoulder and pointed to where the camera crew was setting up. They didn’t know it, but when Misdirection’s illusions dropped, those reporters would be in for a hell of a view. “However, there is one thing we can all agree on, be we Heroes or PEERS. Sometimes, you have to give the people what they want.”

“Ninety-five percent mark cleared,” Dispatch said. “Misdirection, drop the illusion; we now want all attention on the melee distraction team.”

The air around the waiting Heroes shimmered like pavement on a summer afternoon. When the spectacle ended, the mech’s eyes turned toward them. There were audible gasps from the nearby reporters as a giant armor-wearing rabbit suddenly came into view.

“That’s our cue,” Titan said.

“Then by all means, Titan. **Do your best.**” Galvanize turned toward the giant rabbit as its legs tensed, ready to launch itself forward. “**You too, Hopcules.**”

Titan’s whole body tingled, like he’d gotten an unexpected rush of adrenaline. Carefully, he shifted his weight, noting the way the concrete cracked and splintered under him. In almost any other circumstance, this would be dangerous, but facing off against a giant metal monster was one of the few times he didn’t mind having a little extra gas in the tank. If nothing else, it would be interesting to see just what his metaphorical top speed was nowadays. It had been a long time since he needed to find out.

“Thanks,” Titan said, moving with extra caution as he stepped forward. “Now, stay by Topsy. This whole area is about to become a warzone.” With that, Titan leapt forward, only to be passed by Hopcules a few seconds later.



Whatever programming the mech had been built with, whatever counter-strategies designed around the data compiled from previous robot/Hero battles, it had most definitely not been given a ready response for being attacked by a twenty-story tall rabbit. Hopcules' first punch caught it completely by surprise, leaving a massive dent in its six-eyed head. The bunny followed up with a sucker punch to the torso. The echo from the second blow rang through the street. Hexcellent immediately heard Jeremiah's voice snap in her ear.

"Avoid the body blows, if possible. It's already tough enough to move around inside this thing without getting shaken like a martini."

"Don't mind Jeremiah, he's just mad because you made him fall and look undignified," Aether added, her tone much less annoyed. "But do please focus on the extremities. Those are going to do the most damage to the surrounding areas."

"Not a problem." Hexcellent tightened her grip on the bunny's fur and yelled up to its ear, "Grab an arm and snap that shit off!"

Luckily enough, an arm fitted with what looked like a half-dozen machine guns came toward them, no doubt intent on filling the attacking rabbit with countless holes. Before it could take aim, Hopcules grabbed the wrist area, just below the guns, and slammed another hand into the upper arm, straining the elbow joint. Since the damn mech didn't have a back there was nowhere to twist to, so Hopcules just kept piling on more pressure, trying to make the joint snap.

"I'm going to take a wild guess that Hopcules was formed during a time when you watched a lot of wrestling." Titan sounded surprisingly calm given that he was darting around on the other side of the mech, throwing punches into its legs as he tried to cripple the thing's mobility. Hexcellent could already see a tilt in the giant robot's stance, meaning at least one of its legs was now shorter than the others.

"I may or may not have enjoyed the occasional cage match in my childhood." Hexcellent heard the crunch and pop before she actually saw Hopcules pull away the front part of the arm. Her moment of triumph at seeing the threat neutralized was short-lived, however, as a blow from behind

sent Hopcules stumbling forward. Only his gigantic feet saved him from losing his balance entirely.

Whirling around, Hexcellent quickly put together what had happened. While they were trying to take care of one arm, the bot had swung another around and fired a laser blast into Hopcules. Hexcellent scrambled across the shoulder to look down at her summon's back and assess the damage. A huge part of his armor was eroded, and there were singe marks along the skin with burned-off patches of fur. Hopcules didn't seem to have slowed down, but he had to be hurting.

"Don't worry, buddy. We'll pay him back for that." Even Hexcellent was surprised at the fury kindled inside her. Just the sight of her old friend in pain was enough to make her want to turn that fucking mech to bits so thin it could be mistaken for glitter. But she couldn't, because then it would win. So they'd just have to settle for taking away its limbs.

Hopcules swung back around to face its foe, and to Hexcellent's surprise, the mech stepped back slightly. It had seen that the bunny had the upper hand in a melee fight, so now it was trying to keep distance between them. The damned thing was learning, because of course it was: that was what these bastards did. Every time, every iteration, they just came back stronger and more organized, with no actual goal aside from collecting resources and-

"Titan. And Dispatch. And whoever else is listening. I figured it out." Hexcellent couldn't believe it had taken her this long to see what was happening. Though, to be fair, RTS had always been one of her least favorite genres to play. "I know what the robot's motives are."

"We're all ears." The voice was Jeremiah's; Hexcellent was relatively certain she also heard some explosions in the background.

"It's a video game." Hexcellent had to pause as Hopcules leapt out of the way to avoid another laser blast while working to close the gap. The mech kept sliding back, trying to line up its next shot while also dealing with the smaller yet potent threats on the ground.

"Going to need some elaboration," Titan said.

"All of this: the mech, the robots, the motives, it's a real-time strategy game. You make troops then send them out to fight and get resources. You use the experience from those encounters to make more, bigger troops and repeat the process over and over until you can wipe out the enemy. That's why no one could figure out what the fuck these things wanted. *This* is what they

want. These fights.”

“Why in the hell would someone go to all this trouble just to play a game?” Gale snapped.

“No idea, but it’s the first theory I’ve heard that actually fits the pattern,” Jeremiah replied. “Though if anything, it drives home how much we need to make this work. An attack more powerful than this one and the city will be leveled. Distraction team, keep it up; we’ve got a potential match for the signal relay, I’m en route to confirm.”

“Okay, no more slacking,” Hexcellent yelled up to Hopcules. “We got one arm, three to go. You ready?”

In response, Hopcules leapt forward, barely avoiding the latest volley of laser blasts. Fire breath was out since it would melt the people inside the torso as much as the mech, but there was still good old-fashioned grappling. Hopcules slid its giant foot beneath the mech’s legs, knocking three of the remaining four upward. At the same time, he grabbed onto the laser gun that had been taking shots at him with both hand-like paws and jerked upward, trying to use the weight of the falling mech to force a separation at the shoulder.

The idea was a good one, but it failed to account for one important element. After only a few feet, the mech’s fall stopped cold. It righted itself, spinning another arm around to slam the back of Hopcules’ knees, this time successfully sending it to the ground. While Hexcellent couldn’t understand how something that big could stop itself with one leg, Titan knew all too well what had happened as he watched the rabbit fall. Those damn gravity distorters, the ones that made the mechs viable in the first place. It had changed its weight to save itself.

Hopcules struggled to get up while Hexcellent did all she could to hang on, but they were no match for the mech’s inhuman reaction time. The laser arm whipped around, pressing directly into Hopcules’s head, between the ears and the eyes.

At this range, there was no chance the mech was going to miss.

Instants. That was what it always seemed to come down to. All the planning, all the training, all the endless hours trying to imagine how one would deal with a situation, and the truth was that most fights and losses were determined in a span of less than a half-second. That was the hardest thing to try and teach potential Heroes, that in the dire moments they'd be leaning on their instincts. This was why the HCP was so tough on them: when those moments arrived, their reactions had damn sure better be the right ones or people would die.

Titan wasn't perfect. He had a list of names that proved that fact beyond all debate. But he'd been doing the job for a long time, and even if he'd been off for a while, some things never quite faded.

In that moment, as the mech swung its laser cannon towards Hopcules's head, with Hexcellent so close there was no way she wouldn't be caught in the blast, he moved without hesitation, because there was no time for such a luxury. He was betting everything, Hexcellent's everything, on the fact that the mech hadn't changed its weight back from when it stopped its fall. If it could stop itself on one leg, then maybe it could be moved by the same appendage. It was still a roll of the dice, one where snake eyes meant Hexcellent would die. If it came to that, she wouldn't go alone. The least Titan could, and would, do was make sure whoever made these mechanical monsters was sent to join her.

"Everybody hold on!" Titan roared into the comms as he wrapped his arms around the bottom of the mech's nearest leg. No time to try and drag; it could still get off a shot. He needed to completely disorient the damn thing. Slamming his legs through the concrete for stability, Titan's arms crushed into the metal of the leg, creating an unbreakable grip. With all he had, he jerked upwards and to the side, away from Hexcellent. It was ridiculous, it was a flea trying to move a rhino, but it was all he had. He was a strongman. This was the only thing he could do.

But by the gods, he could do it like no one else.

The robot rose from its position atop Hopcules, caught by surprise and unable to react to going suddenly airborne. In the span of seconds it realized what was happening, and Titan felt the metallic beast began to grow rapidly

heavier in his arms. None of that mattered, though, because the real work was already done. Hopcules quickly rolled to the side and sprang back to its oversized feet. He looked unshaken, as near as Titan could tell by reading those glassy black eyes, and no worse for the wear.

“H-holy shit. Kind of thought we were goners there.” Unlike her bunny, Hexcellent was clearly rattled, and Titan couldn’t blame her for that. For someone with no real combat training, she was holding together better than a lot of others would.

“What kind of legendary Hero would I be if I let some asshole machine hurt my teammate?” Titan released his grip on the leg, which came crashing down a few feet away. He wondered if the mech was debating stomping on him, though it had to have realized what little good that would do.

“Clearly not the kind who can manage to keep things smooth for those inside,” Jeremiah grumbled. “Mercifully, we think we’ve found the signal relay. If you can hold out for a few more minutes, I need to get the tracker inserted and let my team do their work.”

“Put a little pep in your step, the bunny almost got taken out,” Titan replied.

“Um. . . yeah. Birdsmen, you’re the veteran summoner here. Have any of yours ever. . . changed?”

Hexcellent’s voice had gone from scared to confused, and it took only a quick glance at Hopcules for Titan to understand why. The giant rabbit was shifting before their very eyes, long serrated claws slipping out of his hands, and new spiky armor growing out of the old. From behind, a vast pair of bat-like wings sprouted. The wings flapped once, sending a breeze across the entire area.

“No. No, I cannot say I’ve ever seen anything quite like that before,” Birdsmen replied from atop his flying stone roc. “Trust me, that’s the sort of thing that would stick in my memories. And my nightmares.”

From above Titan, the mech took another shot with its lasers, and this time Hopcules didn’t dodge. It took the blow right on its chest. The new armor burned but refused to give way. In one shift, the tables had turned and the weaker warrior had grown strong. For the first time, Titan had a feeling of what it must be like for others to fight him.

“I’m no expert, but I’m going to toss out a theory,” Titan said, yanking his feet free from the concrete and making a run for the leg already dented with his handprints. Crippling mobility was the best way he could help now; the rest was going to be up to Jeremiah and Hexcellent. “Hopcules was supposed to keep you safe, right? You made him to fight your fears?”

“That’s how I remember it, but I was a kid,” Hexcellent replied.

“Like I said, this is just a guess. If we assume that’s how it went down, though, then maybe Hopcules is still doing that. He came out so big because you were facing an overwhelming force. Then, when you almost died a few seconds ago, you got scared again, so he grew stronger.”

“Can summons do that?” Hexcellent asked.

“Every Super is different, so it’s possible,” Titan reminded her.

“There have been cases of summons with alteration capabilities under certain situations.” Dispatch was calm, which Titan imagined was only possible because she hadn’t just watched a twenty-story rabbit shape shift. “However, none that we know of were on quite so *grand* a scale.”

“As someone who has to listen to this without knowing what the hell is going on, may I just request that someone take pictures?” Jeremiah asked. “Because it sounds absolutely fascinating.”

“Let’s just say that after I lifted the whole mech, Hexcellent upstaged me.” Titan grabbed the same leg once again, this time digging his hands in and climbing up toward the knee joint. The lasers from the mech’s underside fired at him, but this did little more than singe his clothes. He really needed to ask for a raise; the suit costs were piling up.

“Oh, you want to complain? I just went from being a top-level summoner to some asshole on a bird,” Birdsman added. “At least you got to do something cool. I’m flying around dodging shots.”

“You know, this isn’t quite what I pictured the conversations of Heroes to be like,” Hexcellent admitted.

“We only sound like this when we’re winning,” Jeremiah assured her. “Which, by the way, we are. The tracker is implanted and my team is tracing the signal. Everyone inside the mech, evacuate. As soon as I get confirmation that we’ve found the location, Aether and I will be out of here too. Think you and your upgraded rabbit can handle things from there?”

Titan smashed his hand through the knee joint, causing the mech to wobble as it fired wave after wave of lasers and bullets at the Heroes keeping it distracted. When the machine tipped, he got a clear view to the other side, where Hopcules was flexing his claws and testing his wings. Hexcellent's words crackled over the comms a moment later, all traces of fear gone from her voice.

“You’re damn right we can. Nobody puts my bunny back in the box.”

“Evacuation at eighty percent.” Dispatch’s reports were helpful, but it was visibly obvious that the mech wasn’t clear yet. Colorful costumed forms could be seen leaping from the holes in its body, some breaking into flight while others vanished in midair or landed heavily on the ground.

Hexcellent stood on her rabbit’s shoulder, waiting for the cue to strike as Hopcules dodged the occasional blast. The distraction team had done a great job: the damage to the surrounding area was almost minimal, and the smaller robots were being picked off or contained by the other Heroes. It was hard to call anything in a day like this a win, but knowing how much worse things could have been, Hexcellent felt proud about what they’d accomplished.

That pride was all the more magnified knowing that she’d been able to help. It was almost over; it had only been a taste of the life in the first place. Just one last course to go and she was determined to enjoy it. While Hexcellent didn’t lick her lips in anticipation, it took effort. Part of her wanted to be sad at the ending in sight, at wondering when she would ever be able to summon her oldest friend again, but she pushed those thoughts away. There would be a lifetime of worry and mourning for lost chances when the day was won. Until then, she still had a job to do. For at least the next few minutes, she was a Hero. She was damn sure going to act like it.

“Evacuation at ninety-two percent,” Dispatch said.

“The last of them should be out in the next thirty seconds,” Jeremiah reported from within the beast. “As soon as they’re clear, you need to take this thing apart. I’m not sure if the central system has a way to tell if it’s being tracked, but at this point, we’d be idiots to assume otherwise. We have to scrap this tin can and then book it to the signal source before it has a chance to run.”

“We’ve got teleporters on standby to get us close, and I’m ready to haul the team if it’s a place they’ve never been,” Gale told him.

“Evacuation complete, save for Aether and Jeremiah,” Dispatch announced. “Also, Modus Operandi has confirmed that the signal has been traced to a location approximately thirty miles northeast of Brewster.”



“Then that means we are out of here!” Jeremiah exclaimed. Seconds later, Hexcellent saw him and Aether drop from the middle of the mech’s base, lasers passing through them ineffectually as they headed toward the ground.

“Hexcellent, you are clear for full engagement,” Dispatch said. “There are zero known civilians in the area, so please emphasize expediency over caution.”

“Dispatch, that was an order you really didn’t have to bother giving her,” Titan chuckled. “But good luck, Hexcellent. Everyone will be down here helping out, so tear it apart.”

“We’ll do our best.” She stared at the mech, fending off so many other Heroes that it didn’t even have time to worry about the giant rabbit standing on the sidelines. Maybe it thought they’d been scared away by almost getting shot in the head. Well, they had been scared, but it sure as shit wasn’t away.

“Round two, mother fucker.”

Hopcules barreled forward, and as it did, the costumed warriors parted to let it pass, already waiting for the impending charge. The newly-grown claws hit first, stabbing into the mech’s armored torso with some difficulty. It was a sturdy bastard, Hexcellent had to admit that much, but the holes Eli disintegrated had weakened the structural integrity by a fair bit. Hopcules jerked upward and managed to shred through a chunk of the torso, exposing the gears and circuitry within.

An arm came whirling around, ready to try and put a hole in the mech’s attacker, but this time she and Hopcules were ready for it. Twisting his head, Hopcules opened his mouth wide and bit down on the metal appendage with his mighty buck teeth. Before the mech could struggle free, the smell of melting metal lit the air as Hopcules finally was able to put his fire breath to use. Half of the arm clattered to the concrete, torn off by the combination of heat and strong jaws.

The mech tried to retreat, but Hopcules wasn’t having any of that. Using the claws embedded in its torso, the giant rabbit lifted the mech upward until it was horizontal in the sky. Its arms whipped about, trying to line up a shot while the remaining legs kicked about futilely. Still, Hexcellent waited to give the order. If she wanted this to work, they had to wait for the perfect moment.

For a long, beautiful instant, the mech hung there, suspended by

Hopcules's powerful arms. Then, at last, she saw it start to slide down the rabbit's claws at the same time she felt his shoulders begin to shake. The mech was turning up its weight again, trying to make them let go. She almost felt sorry for the mechanical monster; if only it had worked in a few wrestling games instead of all RTS, it might have seen what she was going for.

"Time for the Back-Breaker, bitch-bot!" Hexcellent yelled, and on cue, Hopcules slammed the mech downward. Not to the ground, where it would have cracked and dented but perhaps still survived, but directly on top of the rabbit's planted knee, where an armored spike happened to be pointing up to the sky. The mech came slamming down, one clawed paw on either side of the knee, pushing with all their might. If it had still been lighter, it might have endured; however, turning up the weight of its body cut both ways.

The mech cracked in half, its weakened torso unable to withstand the combination of weight and muscle that split it down the center of its chest. As soon as its pieces hit the ground, the other Heroes were ready, smashing through the remains or turning them to scraps from afar with ranged powers. No one was taking any chances of this thing getting back up. Hopcules even stomped on the remaining legs, turning them into little more than gleaming silver shards.

"You know, there are a lot of things I don't like about this job. Moments like this are not among them," Jeremiah commented.

"No shit. I need a cigarette after watching that," Aether added.

"You did good, Hexcellent," Titan told her. "A hell of a job. Now we've got to go make the most of what you did and finish things off. Are you going to be okay on your own from here?"

Hexcellent stood atop her giant rabbit summon and looked down at the smoldering wreckage of a monster that she'd bested, yet who hours ago had seemed completely unstoppable.

"I'll be fine, Titan. I just killed a giant robot; right now I am outright fan-fucking-tastic."

From her perch so high up, it was hard to make out Titan as he grouped up with the others, but Hexcellent was almost positive she caught sight of a smile on his face just before his voice came through the comms.

"You're damn right you are."



Northeast of Brewster was a whole lot of nothing, at least as far as Titan was concerned. Some folks enjoyed the loping hills and quasi-mountains, good for hiking and camping and not much else. Despite his rough and tumble appearance, though, Owen Daniels had always preferred life in a city to the more outdoorsy world. Visiting his wife's family in the south had been his only real exposure to the country, and when he'd fled to start his bar, he'd at least picked a place somewhat near civilization. Their enemy's location didn't surprise him or any of the others. An operation of such vast size, the base had to be hidden out in nowhere; otherwise they'd have found it and put this whole thing to bed ages ago.

"This is the closest point I had," Relocate informed them. A teleporter who worked out of Port Valins, he had luckily done an internship in Brewster and had been able to see much of the town. There was no reason for him to have gone so far out in the boonies, though; even a teleporter's encouragement to travel had limits. A few freelance teleporters had been nearby, but they weren't likely to get the team any closer. Besides, Titan never liked taking those types to sensitive areas. DVA-certified transportation resources or not, he preferred to stick with Heroes when things were getting serious.

"We appreciate your help," Jeremiah told Relocate. "It's a few more miles from here, something Gale can easily handle. I'm sure you need to get back to the rescue efforts."

"The requests are already flooding in." Relocate tapped his right ear where Dispatch was no doubt alerting him to the dozens of civilians in need of saving. The robot threat might be suppressed, but the damage they had done had left countless people trapped or in danger. Every Hero that could be spared was pitching in to help, along with emergency services and dozens of PEERS teams. "If you need to make a quick getaway, I can meet you here. Otherwise, there might be a wait for me to get back."

"This isn't a team that plans on running," Gale told him.

"I didn't expect as much, but it seemed polite to offer." Relocate took one last look at his surroundings, refreshing his memory to make the trip back easier, and vanished in a shimmer of static.

“Gale, if you could follow my heading,” Jeremiah said, stepping to the front. “There might be defenses out here: the nearer we get to the signal source the greater chance of that, so everyone be on guard. Aether, be ready to shift Gale and Deadlift if we come under fire.”

“What about you?” Aether didn’t bother asking about Titan, because the answer was obvious: he didn’t need to be intangible. The very best those robots had thrown at him didn’t leave as much as a mark on anything other than his suit. The bots were strong, but Titan had fought stronger.

“I’ll be fine,” Jeremiah assured her. “Worry about these two. Although, Gale, do your powers work when you’re intangible?”

“Never had occasion to find out,” Gale said. “Guess today’s a good chance to learn.”

Deadlift let out a soft groan. “Let’s not tempt fate. Hopefully we’ll make it to the signal without needing to take evasive actions.”

“Hope in one hand, spit in the other. . .” Jeremiah didn’t bother finishing the saying, instead listening attentively to a voice coming through his comm.

As he sat silent, Gale took the opportunity to whip up a whirlwind, raising them all from the ground. Jeremiah was in the front, since he’d be pointing the way, with Deadlift and Gale on either side of Aether so she could reach them. Titan was in the rear, a hardy shield in case something tried to come at them from behind.

“That way,” Jeremiah said finally, gesturing out toward a hill overgrown with lush green trees. “Based on the topography my people are looking at, we’ll pass over two hills and a small lake before we get to the right area.”

With no more than the point of a finger they were off, tearing through the sky at breakneck speeds. Though she was doing a good job staying controlled, Titan could nearly feel the rage coming from Gale. He liked Brewster, but to him it was just a city. To her, however, it was a place of incredible importance. It was where her team had been based for decades, where the legacy of Elemental Fury took root. More than that, she’d lived there for years; she knew the city and the people in it intimately. This attack hadn’t just been horrific for her on a human level, it had hit her personally. When they found whoever was responsible for it, Titan knew he was going to have to move fast. If the culprit wasn’t captured quickly, Gale might do

something she would ultimately live to regret. Killing was never easy, and if it was done without need she'd be weighed down by that sin for the rest of her life.

The ground below them flew by. In no time they were zipping past the lake Jeremiah had described. He motioned for Gale to begin their descent. Near as Titan could tell, there was nothing that marked the area they were heading for as noteworthy, just a small ravine and more hills full of trees. Of course, if the base could be seen from the sky, they wouldn't have needed to use such extreme tracking methods in the first place. Slowly, following Jeremiah's directions, Gale brought them down, past the lip of the ravine, deeper into the crevice where the late-afternoon sun could scarcely reach. At last, Titan felt the familiar sensation of earth beneath his feet.

It turned out that the ravine was deeper than he'd perceived from the sky, a narrow slice in the land that felt like two walls looming over them. Thankfully, Hero gear didn't lose signal easily. Jeremiah began trekking across the rocky terrain, following the guidance of his unseen team. The more Titan watched Modus Operandi accomplish, the more curious he was about the other members. It wasn't unheard of for Subtlety Heroes to buck the spotlight, but a whole team represented by one Hero seemed peculiar. Then again, they were bound to be making all manner of enemies, given how efficient they were, and Subtlety Heroes often weren't known for their combat skills. Maybe putting up one lone giant target to go after made sense, assuming Jeremiah could handle the burden.

"We're getting close," Jeremiah called, waving for them to follow. "The signal is coming from nearby, and my team says this is the most likely point to have an entrance. If we don't find one, then I'm going to need Aether to do some intangible recon through the rock, and then Titan can bust open--"

Before Jeremiah could finish his plan, he took one step too far, and what seemed to be nothing more than a clump of rocks suddenly sprang to life. It whirred and clicked, whipping around and locking the barrel of its laser gun directly on Jeremiah. Titan started running as soon as he saw the motion, but he wasn't nearly fast enough. The sound of a high-pitched whine filled the air, then a flash of red shot from the barrel. After that, there was only Titan's thundering footsteps and the soft slump of a body hitting the ground.

The hole in Jeremiah's chest where his heart should be was still smoking, the horrid smell of roasting flesh wafting through the air.



The gun was nothing more than scrap metal after two of Titan's blows, both of which were far stronger than were strictly necessary. Though he hadn't yet turned to make the confirmation, he knew what he'd witnessed while dashing over. Jeremiah was dead. Whatever enhanced endurance he might have had wasn't enough to withstand the laser blast. A hole in the chest was enough to kill pretty much anything, even a Super.

With the remains of the laser throwing off sparks, Titan turned to find the others clustered around Jeremiah, whose blood was soaking into the rocks. No doubt about it: he was dead, likely had been before he hit the ground. Aether's face was pale, and Deadlift seemed to be sniffing under his mask; the poor kid probably hadn't lost too many friends in the field yet. Much as Titan wanted to mourn the loss of a comrade—a loss hitting Titan harder than he'd expected—Jeremiah's death meant nothing if they didn't finished the job.

"We need to—" Titan's words died on his tongue as Jeremiah's pooling blood suddenly halted, then began to flow back into his blown apart torso. As it did, the burned out chunks of flesh lengthened and bones regrew. The whole process took perhaps five seconds, but when it was done, Jeremiah's body bore no sign of any injury whatsoever. If that alone wasn't disturbing enough, the sound of a rough cough escaped the fallen Hero's lips, and he shook his head as if coming out of a long nap.

"*What the fuck!*" Aether screeched, turning insubstantial and leaping backward. Even for people who dealt with superhuman abilities, someone coming back from the dead was a bit much. Gale and Deadlift both took defensive postures as well; bracing for attack was their default reaction in strange situations.

"Sorry about that," Jeremiah said, voice as calm as if he hadn't just had his heart hollowed out seconds earlier. "Little inconvenient, I know, but at least now we know to be on guard for traps."

"You were dead." Titan looked around for any proof of the injury, splatters of blood or flecks of bone, yet there was no sign of it aside from the hole in Jeremiah's shirt. Even the blood stains on the rocks were gone. "This. . . this is impossible. What you just did goes way beyond regeneration. This is



time manipulation.”

“Come on, if I was the first Super to travel through time, you don’t think I’d work on a slightly grander scale than running a team of Subtlety Heroes?” Jeremiah slowly pulled himself to his feet and gestured over to the broken wreckage of the gun that had slain him. “Besides, if I never got shot, then you never would have beaten that device halfway to electronic hell. Appreciate that, by the way.”

“Jeremiah, we all just watched you die. Regeneration can’t fix death. Do you really expect us to just let this pass with no explanation?” Gale’s eyes were narrowed, her emotions torn between relief and uncertainty of what to make of such a display.

“At the very least, we need to know how much damage you can come back from before we go any further.” Deadlift thrust a thumb down the ravine, where logic said there were no doubt more traps lying in wait for them. “Not to be a dick about it, but knowing what actually kills you tells us who we should prioritize helping if things turn to shit without warning.”

Jeremiah turned the argument around a few times before evidently landing on agreement with the point. “Very well, but I’m only giving you all the cursory overview. As a Subtlety Hero, I know far too well how important it is to have a few secrets kept close to the vest, especially about weaknesses. The long and short of it is that my body doesn’t regenerate, technically. It’s more apt to say that I lock my physical form in at a certain time, and my ability maintains that status quo no matter what happens.”

“What the hell does that mean?” Aether had largely recovered from her outburst, though she was still giving Jeremiah a wary eye as he explained. No one, least of all Jeremiah, blamed her for the caution. Seeing a corpse pull itself back together was unsettling on a lot of levels.

“It means I pick a day when I’m exactly where I want to be. Fit, strong, energetic, and without any aches or pains. Then I activate my power. And until I turn it off, that’s my body, regardless of outside forces like giant robots or laser cannons-”

“Or time?” It was Titan who interrupted, realizing exactly what Jeremiah was describing. Immortality. Maybe not perfect: if he was keeping secrets then there was bound to be a flaw or two in the ability. No power was unbeatable. Yet if he really did lock his body like he was describing, it meant aging wasn’t something he had to fear.

The wide grin on Jeremiah's face answered before he formed the first syllable of his glib reply. "I haven't had enough years to say for certain yet, but by all accounts going forward, I'm going to look extremely good for my age, whatever that might be. Though at the rate I'm mowing through uniforms, I'll have a huge clothing bill and a lot of unpleasant death memories."

"Wait, do you remember dying from the laser?" Gale asked.

"I remember everything that happens to me before the power gets triggered," Jeremiah told her. "That's the drawback to my ability; I can recall every single time my life has ended, and let me tell you, those memories are not sunshine and rainbows. Still, it's the gift I have, so I make the most of it."

"And it sounds like a hell of a good one, but I think it's about time we started using *my* power." Titan turned toward the direction the laser gun had sprung up from. "Everyone, stay here. I'm going to see if there are any more traps waiting."

He began jogging forward, through the ravine's narrow walls. Within the first few steps, another gun burst forth from the rocks, firing directly at Titan's torso. The burning energy hit his already-exposed flesh. It fizzled uselessly just before Titan returned the blow, his force leaving only shattered scrap behind. A few more feet and another gun appeared, quickly meeting the same fate. Further in and an explosion from the ground tried to blow off his leg, succeeding only in tearing up his boot. Titan continued on, undeterred. Seeing a friend die, even if only for a few moments, had been just the kick in the ass he needed to remind him of his role in situations like this. It had been a long time since Titan was doing real Hero work, but with each step forward, it was coming back to him. His place was at the front, taking on every attack the enemy could throw, making sure his team stayed safe.

Titan would stand against the full assault, and only when it was spent would he call the others to follow. That was what it meant to be a team's shield.

As it turned out, they didn't need Aether to search the walls for an entrance. The traps and devices Titan was charging through, while no doubt designed to keep unwanted guests from ever getting near the hidden base, served in this case as a trail of breadcrumbs leading the team of Heroes right to the door. True, it looked like nothing more than a ravine wall marking a natural end to their journey, but with one punch from Titan, before any of the others could arrive to suggest a more nuanced entrance, the reinforced door blew backward in shards, revealing a softly-lit, smooth metal hallway leading deeper underground.

"Well, there goes any element of surprise we might have had," Jeremiah noted as he, Gale, Aether, and Deadlift emerged from the wake of Titan's destruction.

"Between the cannons, mines, and laser grids, I have a feeling anyone in here already knew we were coming," Titan replied, words purposely absent anything resembling an apology. "If I can't surprise an enemy, I prefer to let them know I mean business, and nothing says I wipe my ass with your security quite like punching a door off its hinges."

"Actually, it looks like this didn't have hinges. It rose up to let people in, making it all the harder to knock down." Deadlift had walked to the doorway and was staring into the ruined mechanism of the entrance. "Quite a functional design. I mean, under different circumstances."

"Since time is now officially not on our side, how about we get going with this?" Gale suggested. "Jeremiah, do those voices in your head happen to have any insight on where the signal is coming from? Or are we flying blind from this point on?"

"Hey, they got us here, didn't they?" Jeremiah bristled a touch, more bothered by the barb than by his death only a few moments prior. "And no, I don't have direct lock on where we need to go. They can play hot and cold using my location and the signal strength, but this place is too deep and well-shielded to get the signal's exact coordinates. Besides, the machine sending the orders and the Super who built it aren't guaranteed to be in the same position, and we need to stop the latter more than the former."

"Then it looks like we're splitting up." Aether had gone intangible and

walked down the hallway unbeknownst to the rest of them until she came sauntering back up. “Thought I’d do a bit of recon while you bickered about plans. The hallway splits off in three directions from here. If we’re hunting two separate targets then it seems like we’ve got to cover all the branches to be safe.”

“Safe would be moving as a team down each one until we’d searched them all,” Titan pointed out.

“But that gives our Super better odds of escaping,” Gale countered. “Aether is right: we need to scour the base as quickly as possible. Five doesn’t split up evenly, so we’ll pair off as needed. Deadlift, you’re a rookie, no offense, which means I’ll feel better seeing you with someone who knows what they’re doing. Go with Titan. Since Jeremiah is apparently unkillable, but lacks much in terms of offense, he and Aether should be able to skirt past any obstacles they encounter. I’ll take on my path solo.”

“Shouldn’t Titan go solo?” Deadlift suggested. “He’s the one who would be in the least danger of getting hurt or captured.”

“Gale can take care of herself just as well as I can,” Titan said quickly, hoping to cut Gale off before she tore into the relatively new Hero. “She leads a team into dangerous situations all the time, and her power is suited to offense and defense. What she can’t do is shield someone else as easily as I can. You’re with me because if things go bad, I’ll hopefully be able to take the brunt of whatever gets thrown at us.”

“Make sure to stay behind him.” Jeremiah patted Deadlift softly on the back. “Unlike me, your insides probably don’t put themselves back together once they see daylight.”

Titan didn’t bother adding any agreement to Jeremiah’s words. The image of his corpse splayed out on the ground was still fresh in all their minds, a perfect reminder of where one misstep in situations like these could lead. Instead, he headed down the hallway, once again taking his position ahead of the others. Unlike his trek through the ravine, Titan’s heavy footsteps didn’t trigger any cannons or traps; only echoes met him as he plunged deeper into the hidden base. Soon he arrived at the split Aether had described, three hallways branching off from the one he’d descended. Rather than waste more time debating, Titan merely looked back to make sure Deadlift was following and walked right up the one in the middle.

From behind, Titan heard Deadlift’s hurried steps as he ran to catch

up, while Gale, Jeremiah, and Aether all went to either side of them. Without knowing where any of this led, it was impossible to say who was on the fastest path, or the most dangerous. Though, Titan did have a hunch or two.

“Is there a reason you picked the middle hall?” Deadlift asked, speaking up to be heard from the several feet behind Titan where he was trailing. “It’s fine if it’s random, but since I’ve been so strongly reminded of my rookie status, I thought I might as well ask so I could learn something.”

A few more heavy steps, and Titan caught sight of a bend in the hall. It might have been his imagination, but it seemed like a different source of light than the gently glowing bulbs along the wall was shining from around the corner.

“It wasn’t random,” Titan told Deadlift, even as he held up his hand for the other Hero to stop advancing. “You need to hang back here. There might be something ready to fire as soon as I turn the corner, and I’d rather not have you caught up in the blast if it’s explosive.”

“If we hadn’t just walked through a valley of mechanical death, I might call you paranoid.” Despite the sass, Deadlift came to an immediate stop, even going so far as to take a few steps backward. “What’s my cue that it’s safe to follow?”

“Depends. I might just yell for you, though there’s always the chance that the room will be soundproofed, so I may come back this way or pass a message through Dispatch. Just be ready to move if I give an order. Especially if that order is to run.”

“Consider me raring to go,” Deadlift replied.

Titan started forward again, but Deadlift’s voice caused him to stop as it yelled one last question from behind.

“If it’s not random, then why did you pick the middle hall?”

“Just a hunch built on experience.” Titan’s mind swam back through the years of busting into bases, lairs, and dens of criminal activity. They didn’t always have time to prepare defenses, but when they did, most followed a similar pattern.

“Everyone almost always puts the bulk of their defenses up the middle. And there was no way I was going to let someone else have all our fun.”



Though he was braced for attack, the light from around the corner wasn't coming from any sort of cannon, bomb, or even menacing robot. That would have made sense. No, what Titan found awaiting him as he headed down this new bend of the hall was far stranger than a mere defense mechanism. It was a catwalk, half-rusted steel stretched out over a deep hole before several elevators. He tested the metal carefully, expecting it to give way under his sizable weight, but found it didn't even wobble. Looking closer, Titan realized that while the initial structure had aged poorly, new parts had been rotated in to secure everything in place.

With each step, he waited, sure something from the dark chasm beneath his feet, where elevator rails went deeper than he could make out, would come leaping up to attack him. Yet his movement was greeted only by the barely-audible echoes of what sounded like some sort of distant activity.

"Dispatch, put me in everyone's ear," Titan said. Without bothering to wait for confirmation he continued, "Deadlift, you can go ahead and follow me in, just be careful. I could be wrong, but I'm pretty sure I walked into the top floor of a mining operation."

"Oh please don't tell me this whole thing was just Old Man Caruthers digging for diamonds and trying to throw people off the scent," Aether sighed. "If we unmask a *Scooby Doo* villain after all that destruction I'm going to be so pissed."

"Just throwing out a guess, but they might have been digging for ore," Jeremiah said. "They probably dug out as much as they could and bought up the rest on the down low. Robots take metal, and unless you've got access to a really gifted Super, metal doesn't make itself."

"That would have to be a lot of ore," Gale told them. From her side of the mic, Titan thought he could pick up the muffled sounds of wind and a small explosion. "Also, I met a welcoming committee. Not many of them yet, but stay on guard."

"Yeah, be glad you're not with us." Aether's voice was full of something that was not quite awe but certainly a sense of being impressed. "We found the factory section that's churning those bots out. Things are up and running, though most of them are incomplete. I think they sent every bot

they had out after us today.”

“Well, almost.” Jeremiah’s tone was about as close to worried as Titan had heard it since the giant mechs dropped from the sky. “I found what appear to be spare parts for a pretty sizable bot that doesn’t look like anything we’ve fought so far. Smart money says this place has a watchdog that was left behind.”

Titan heard the sound of footsteps on the catwalk and swung around, ready to beat back whatever mechanical guardian had been sent to stop him. Instead, he found Deadlift, who took a very healthy step back even though he was well out of punching range.

“Sorry,” Titan mumbled, forcing himself to relax. “I’m a little on edge.”

“And why wouldn’t you be? We’re just poking around a hidden, massive robot factory, standing atop a patchwork walkway over what sure looks like an infinite hole to nowhere.” Deadlift took a careful peek over the side, then immediately pulled himself back to the center of the catwalk. “Okay, seriously, how in the hell did a place like this get built under our noses?”

“From the looks of most of the stuff here, I think it was made a long time ago,” Jeremiah told them. “A lot of this equipment is crazy high-tech, but everything non-essential is still rusty and broken. This place might have been built back before Brewster was ever much of a metropolis. Old lair of a criminal who either went to jail or was buried is my guess, probably found by someone who didn’t mind a fixer-upper.”

“Not the first opportunistic squatter I’ve had to oust,” Gale said. “When this is over, we probably need to catalogue this place and see what all is here. If it was a villain’s lair, there might be useful files or documents.”

“Hey, don’t go stealing my lines. I don’t run around kicking the shit out of bad guys from midair,” Jeremiah replied.

Titan ignored them, not because he disagreed, but because his focus for the moment was on making it across the rest of the catwalk. Near the middle, things had gotten a bit shakier, and while the catwalk continued to hold his weight, Titan again found himself looking down to the empty gulf of darkness at his feet and wondering how long it would take him to climb back up. More importantly, he tried to figure out how he’d save Deadlift if the metal floor did give way.



Mercifully, he didn't need to think up an answer, as they both eventually made it all the way to the end of the catwalk and set foot back on the shiny silver ground. Titan continued forward until he reached a fork in the path. He began down the right side, holding up his hand so Deadlift would wait. Within a minute he could feel the heat coming from up ahead. If they were mining ore then they'd need a forge, and while it was possible his prey was hiding in there, Titan found it highly unlikely. This much heat from this far off meant the temperature in the forge was more than any human without enhanced endurance could comfortably withstand. It was possible, true, but his gut said to check the other branch first before going after long shots.

Backtracking to Deadlift, Titan headed down the left path, which after a minute proved to be absent of the wall of heat. He called for Deadlift to follow, who did so at a safe distance. They wound their way deeper into the hidden base, passing a few dusty workstations that had held up surprisingly well and one ancient computer that looked like it weighed more than the desk it was sitting on. Along the way they got progress reports from the others, who were encountering similar findings.

One thing worried Titan as they made their way farther through the halls: the others were dealing with patrols. Never too many and none so strong that they weren't easily handled, but still, the other Heroes were fighting robots. Meanwhile, he and Deadlift continued to encounter a whole lot of nothing. It was unnerving, all the more so because Titan had thought this would be the most perilous path. Why was this one seemingly undefended?

As it turned out, the answer to that question was waiting for him a few turns further down the hallway. In one angled step, Titan left the ubiquitous shiny hallway and entered a massive room with a dome-shaped ceiling. From the number of shattered chairs and retro couches, Titan guessed that once upon a time this had been some sort of break or social room. That was long since passed, though. Standing amidst the wreckage that it must have created while opening up the area was a nine-foot-tall robot unlike any that Titan had seen before. Thick limbs, glass eyes pulsing with green light, and all manner of small devices adorned the various nooks and crannies of its body.

Titan didn't even bother to turn; he trusted that Deadlift would take one look at the situation and know to stay back. This thing wasn't like the smaller robots. This was something special, maybe even a new model, a sneak preview at what would have come with the next encounter.

“Hey guys,” Titan said, moving carefully into the large room. “Got a hunch that I found the watchdog.”

As his foot crossed from the hallway over the room’s threshold, the robot bolted forward. That, Titan had been expecting. What came next, however, took him by surprise. Its unwavering gaze stayed trained on him as its mouth parted and a thick, electronic voice echoed around them.

*“You!”*

Of all the things Titan had seen the robots do since their arrival in Brewster, talking had never been among their bag of tricks. Hearing the robot angrily yell at him in recognition was enough to take even Titan by surprise, which was why he was a few seconds slow in raising his arm to stop the giant metal fist surging toward him. He managed a half-block, not that it made much difference. The blow sent him spiraling through the air until he crashed into a nearby wall, leaving a sizable dent in the dense material.

If its talking had been a surprise, then the robot moving him was an outright shocker. True, he hadn't been properly braced for the attack, but he still should have been able to compensate for such a strike. It hadn't even felt that strong, really, at least not compared to attacks from some of the more powerful Supers he'd brought down through the years. Yet he'd gone sailing like he was still fresh out of the HCP, and that was no small feat for anyone to accomplish.

"Do we know each other?" Titan asked, hurriedly rising to his feet and getting into a proper fighting stance. A surprise attack was one thing, but he'd be damned if he let this metal bastard toss him around so easily again.

"I know you. Ever since you appeared, the game has been tilted. You are an unbalanced resource and must be removed from the board. Father searched the enemy archives for every bit of data and video about you, Titan. Then he gave me strength and knowledge so that I could destroy you." Again, the robot charged, not even missing a syllable in its rant as it dashed across the floor. Another punch flew, this one on track for Titan's head, but the metal opponent no longer had the advantage of surprise.

Titan grabbed the fist as it drew near him, spinning the arm over his shoulder as he aimed to throw the robot into the wall. It tried to counter instantly, showing that perhaps the speech about knowing his moves hadn't been a bluff. Unfortunately for it, every counter it attempted relied on taking control of the movement or breaking Titan's grip, and the strength difference between them was just too much for it to overcome.

A loud cracking filled the air as the robot's torso smashed into the wall, eclipsing Titan's dent with one of its own. Rather than lie there or try and break the firm grip Titan still had on its arm, the robot kicked its legs

against the wall. It was a small motion, and at its current angle leverage was almost impossible, which was why Titan was all the more shocked as they both went spinning through the air. In his moment of confusion, the arm in his clutches slipped away, and they both landed on the ground several feet apart.

“You’ve got one of those gravity distortion things,” Titan said, understanding finally setting in. “That’s how you sent me flying before.”

“One of the many tools I was equipped with to bring you down.” The robot couldn’t smile; its facial features weren’t constructed in such a way to accommodate expressions. All the same, Titan could swear there was something like a grin on its face as he watched the indentation of his handprint on its arm slowly undent. Great; this one had the self-repair capacity, too.

“You are an improper variable, Titan. The abilities you possess alone are imbalanced, but far worse is the effect you have on other enemy resources. Small threats became larger and non-threats became tremendously unbalanced assets in their own right. The common link at the scenes was you. You can sway the tide of engagements, and so I was made especially to counteract your presence.”

“Yeah? They should have put more pistons in your arms then; I can barely even feel your attacks,” Titan replied. Something wasn’t sitting easy with him. This robot had to know that in terms of power, it was massively inferior to him. Yet it didn’t seem rattled in the slightest. If anything, it was cocky. That was strange enough: who built dickishness into a simulated personality? But obviously there was some hidden card yet to be played, and the robot seemed to think it would turn things around.

“Not even with all the resources Father collected was he able to fashion a creature to match your strength,” the robot agreed. “But not every engagement needs to be won by force. And not every punch is just a punch.”

His feet were off the floor before he had a chance to so much as grab for the ground, not that it would have helped. As he rose rapidly into the air, Titan groped and spun, trying to wriggle free of whatever force was holding him captive. The trouble was that there didn’t seem to be anything to fight against. It was like the strings keeping him anchored to the ground had been cut, and now he was just drifting in place with no method of moving forward.

“Though this last engagement was lost, Father gained a tremendous amount of data in the battles. I am the first of the next line. Rushed and

imperfect though I may be, I was still gifted with the newest innovations Father could conceive of. He was inspired by the way you all crawled about in his mighty destroyer units, so he began producing insect-sized units that easily could be planted on an enemy. Normally, they would burrow into the skin, destroying the resource from the inside out. In your case, however, they serve as precise targeting locations, allowing the room's gravity distorter to manipulate your local field just perfectly enough to remove you from the battle."

Titan whipped his gaze around and caught sight of a small, ant-sized speck of metal as it moved between the burned away sections of his shirt. As he did, he took notice of the room again, this time with fresh eyes. He'd assumed the disarray of broken furniture had been cleared from the room's center for a slug-fest; now he understood the real purpose. The robot had taken away anything with which he might grab and use to navigate. This room, too, with its high domed ceiling had probably been selected for the task. Even the robot's appearance, bulky and muscular, had been meant to lure him in with melee expectations. The whole thing was a giant trap, and he'd stepped right into it like a damn rookie.

"So, what now?" Titan asked. His mind worked furiously as he tried to figure out what to do next. The projectiles he kept for such occasions were in a compartment on his belt, but with how resilient these robots were, there was no guarantee that even a perfect throw would take his opponent down. He needed to think of something, and soon. "You going to use me as a punching bag until you build up enough strength to do some damage? If you're supposed to destroy me, this is a pretty piss-poor job of it."

"Oh, have no fear; there are new weapons Father wants to test. You'll make an excellent guinea pig. But that comes later. And as for destroying you, a captured enemy asset is a neutralized asset. That will do until a permanent solution can be found. In the meantime, we both know you're not the only enemy who is attempting to assail Father's base." The robot turned, looking down the hallway where Deadlift would be, still waiting on a signal from Titan to move forward.

"I'll handle you after I'm done neutralizing the rest of your fellow assets."

Despite his initial impulse, Titan forced himself to stay calm as he watched the robot head toward the hallway. Getting angry, while useful in the right moments of battle, did jackshit to aid clear thinking. Stepping into this trap was bad enough; he couldn't afford to stay snared while that bastard went after the other Supers. In terms of power alone, they were probably better than the bot, but the way it had been so perfectly equipped to deal with him left Titan fearful that he wasn't the only one it knew how to stop. Especially separated as they were, it might just manage to get the upper hand. Even if it succeeded once, that was too many times. He had to think of something, fast, to keep the damn robot's attention on him.

Yanking free one of his projectiles, Titan let the steel ball fly directly into the metal back. It pierced the surface cleanly—so cleanly that Titan realized he'd put more power into the throw than intended—before bursting out the other side and slamming into the ground. The robot, now with a small hole running through its body, turned to look at Titan yet remained silent.

"I didn't think we were done having our match," Titan said, another orb dancing along in the palm of his hand.

"A quaint notion. My brothers might have fallen for that, prioritizing the immediate threat over what seem to be secondary ones. But today you showed Father that we are weakened if we rely on his instructions alone. I was made greater, smarter, closer to his image. And I know a petty attempt at distraction when I see it. You are neutralized, Titan. Accept it gracefully, as a good resource should."

"For someone who's so smart, you don't seem to know shit about how comms work." That voice came from neither Titan nor the robot, but rather from Deadlift, who had darted around the corner. Over his head was a massive bucket, so large it must have been scraping the hallway's ceiling, securely nestled inside a dense section of metal at least three feet thick. Even a normal strongman would have struggled with the load, or at least been slowed by it, but Deadlift moved as if it weighed no more than a thought, which for him it likely didn't.

"The asset known as Deadlift. High strength capacity observed but minimal ability to withstand damage," the robot said. Its left hand began to

glow with an ominous green light, one that Titan had no doubt would cut through the younger Hero just like Jeremiah in the ravine except, obviously, that Deadlift didn't have any healing powers. "Permanent neutralization will be—"

Whatever the robot's opinions on neutralization might have been, they went unheard as Deadlift swung his bucket forward. While the metal shit-talker was no doubt expecting some sort of solid mass, Titan's vantage point afforded him a peek inside the container to the red hot liquid bubbling within. Deadlift had raided the forge, which explained why there was a massive container between his hands and bucket. He swung his weapon and a golden-red liquid sprayed through the air in a wave of molten destruction.

Moving with appropriately inhuman speed, the robot darted to the side, getting clear of the fiery goop before it had entirely left the bucket. Their opponent came up with its arm raised, a muzzle sliding out from between its ring and middle finger as the whole hand restructured itself into a ranged weapon. Taking aim, it again almost looked like it was smiling just before it squeezed off the shot.

"You missed," it declared, and fired on Deadlift.

The beam of energy, no doubt meant to tear flesh and organs apart down to their very molecules, failed to pierce its target. This was not the fault of the robot's aim or the gun's firing. Rather, it was because a massive slab of muscular torso, still coated in burning hot metal, raced forward and put itself between the beam and Deadlift.

"No, he didn't." Titan could actually feel the heat from the molten liquid as it dripped down his skin, which spoke volumes to just how hot it really was. Deadlift hadn't managed to coat Titan completely in the stuff, but he'd gotten good coverage: enough to instantly kill a large number of those damn tiny robots crawling on Titan's skin while the residual heat cooked the rest. With no mini-bots to target, the gravity field couldn't lock on, and Titan was once again a free man.

"Thanks for the assist," he said, never daring to take his eyes off the robot, who still had a gun trained on him.

"I might be a rookie, but I still know enough to listen in for a teammate having a tough time," Deadlift replied.

"I can see that. Now why don't you slip back into the hallway real quick? This is about to get nasty, and I don't want any collateral damage."

Titan darted forward, well-aware that Deadlift would need a distraction to get clear. That was something he was happy to provide, as all the anger he'd been keeping at bay finally had an outlet, and it was the momentarily-befuddled mechanical bastard right in front of him.

The robot opened its mouth, probably to make a quip, but Titan didn't bother listening. It had been too long, he'd gotten used to working as a corpie, there were all manner of excuses he could make for himself about why he'd fallen into such a simple trap. None of them would have mattered, though. Not if he let his fellow Heroes pay the price for his mistake. Thanks to Deadlift, he'd gotten a second chance. As a man who knew how rare those were, Titan had no inclination to waste it.

His first punch shattered the bot's left arm, the one it had used to try and kill his friend. As he attacked, the robot tried to throw more of the mini-bots on him. The smelted liquid was still burning strong though, and they dissolved as soon as they made contact. The heat was adding something extra to his punches as well, flecks of molten metal spraying onto the robot and sizzling atop its exterior. The left arm was scrap in seconds, smashed apart with extra blows to ensure it couldn't be put back together.

"This is improper!" The robot was backpedaling, trying to put distance between itself and the rampaging Titan. "You are an imbalanced resource! That asset shouldn't have even been here, let alone been skilled enough to aid you. You shouldn't exist."

"There are plenty of people who agree with you, go ahead and get in line." Titan kept after it, refusing to allow any chance for new plans to spring into the damn thing's head. This was how he should have attacked from the start. It wasn't his job to play with these things, taking his time and enjoying the fights. He was supposed to clear the path, no matter what lay ahead of him. Another strike, and this time the robot's right leg broke away, turned to shards under Titan's stomping feet.

A flash of red light filled the air as the robot fired from a gun on its right hand. The laser hit well, right in Titan's torso, but only succeeded in leaving a small red dot on his chest. That alone was pretty impressive, by Titan's standards, anyway.

Seeing its attack fail, his opponent attempted to flee, crawling away slowly with its remaining limbs.

"Why?" The cocky tone had faded; what remained was pleading, so



close to human it nearly made Titan hesitate. Then he remembered the attempt to kill his teammate seconds ago, and he continued his pursuit. “Why do you exist?” the thing asked. “Why do you continue breaking the parameters?”

Another audible crunch as Titan wrecked the last leg. The right arm half-heartedly swung around to clock him, and he caught it effortlessly. The robot stared up at him, its last limb captured. Small compartments on its chest opened, deploying miniature bombs and laser blasts that bounced uselessly off Titan’s looming body.

“Why won’t you quit? Why won’t you just *die*?”

“That’s easy,” Titan said, ripping the last arm free from the robot’s body and wrapping his mighty hand around its dense head. “Because I haven’t earned the right yet.”

One tug and the head was clear of the torso. Less than a minute later, the body was reduced to scrap. Titan stood over it, waiting to see if enough remained to try and repair. Only when it remained still did he relax, turning the robot’s head around in his hands as he looked at the destruction scattered throughout the room.

“When you die, it’s over,” Titan said, all too aware he was talking to a lifeless hunk of metal. “No more work or fear or responsibility. I don’t deserve that kind of peace. Not until I make amends for all the things I’ve fucked up.”

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It took some time for Deadlift and Titan to continue on, mostly because the latter paused to try and get as much molten liquid off his body as possible. As the material cooled it became easier—a few flexed muscles could shatter the hardened metal—but it still required a solid five minutes before Titan felt he'd wiped away enough to continue.

During that time, Deadlift said nothing, merely watching in amusement as the older Hero was annoyed by a substance that would have killed most people outright, Supers included.

"You really are indestructible, aren't you?" Deadlift noted as Titan finally stopped trying to clean himself off. "I had a hunch that stuff wasn't going to kill you. . . I mean, I've seen you take a lot of damage. . . but you didn't even lose a step. It could have just as easily been room-temperature water for how much it bothered you."

"No one is invincible, or indestructible, or unkillable," Titan replied automatically. "Not me, not people like Jeremiah, no one. Always keep that in mind. When Supers forget that, bad things happen. Sometimes they go out of control with power and need to be brought down. Sometimes they lose their nerve during a tough fight and innocent people die. No power is perfect. As someone who has spent a big chunk of his life training and fighting other Supers, I should know."

Titan looked around the room, noting that there was only one exit out aside from the hallway they'd entered through. With nowhere else to go, their path forward was obvious. As they began to leave, however, he noticed that Deadlift was keeping closer than before. It was tempting to chastise the rookie, but given that Deadlift had just saved him and possibly the rest of the team, Titan held his tongue. The kid had shown good judgment so far; if he wanted to stay closer then that was his call. For now.

"You know, I've gotten that speech from a lot of people, Dean Bishop key among them. Yet every time I see more of what you can do, I find myself wondering just how true it is. Maybe someone could have killed you when you were young and inexperienced, but now. . . I watched you lift a mech today, Titan. And shrug off who knows how many attacks. You're really going to stand there and tell me you've never once considered the possibility

that you might be the exception to the rule?”

Without warning, Titan stopped walking. He turned to face Deadlift, all too aware that their comms were still on. That was fine, though. This was something the others should hear, just in case they ever needed the information.

“Strong as I am, Deadlift, I’m still vulnerable to things I haven’t faced before. True, after years of Hero work that’s a small category, but it’s a big world with new Supers appearing all the time. And to answer your question, no, I’ve never thought myself invincible. Because I know how the DVA plans to kill me if I ever go out of control.”

Lifting his hand, Titan delicately tapped the side of his temple three times. “There’s a Super out in Kentucky with the power to manifest brain aneurisms. Never went Hero, since he didn’t think his power was suited to protecting people, but sometimes the DVA taps him to bring down especially dangerous or troublesome criminals. Temporarily Authorized Hero Asset, same exception they used for Hexcellent and Eli. I’ve got no resistance to that ability, and I’ve never been called on a case to fight anyone with similar powers. That’s how they’ll kill me, if I ever go rogue.”

“Holy Hell,” Aether whispered over the comms. “They told you about this? Just gave you the name of your executioner in case ever you stepped foot out of line?”

“Actually, Titan was the one who suggested we keep the aforementioned Super on retainer, just in case.” Dispatch was as calm as ever, slipping in only to correct a misassumption in the conversation and then going silent.

“Why would you do that?” Deadlift asked.

“Jeremiah, Gale, either of you want to field this one for me?” Titan asked.

“Because Heroes need to be aware of their mortality,” Gale replied. “For those of us like me and Deadlift, because it keeps us smart and safe in dangerous situations. For those like Titan and Jeremiah, it keeps them grounded, reminds them that even *their* actions have consequences.”

Deadlift stared at Titan with new eyes, though whether they were filled with respect or incredulity Titan didn’t have time to puzzle out. He merely turned back around and continued walking down the mysterious

hallway, idly wondering if he'd have to fight another of those talking robots. He hoped not; there was something about destroying an opponent who could have conversations that left a bad taste in Titan's mouth. AI was impossible, as far as the official records went, but that didn't mean it would stay that way forever.

"As an aside, the DVA probably has assets that Titan isn't aware of to tap, backups in case he decides to snuff out his failsafe in advance," Jeremiah added. "I've poked around enough to know they've got contingency plans for me, and I'm nowhere near as dangerous as he is. Well, not as immediately dangerous, anyway. Given a little time and research, I can be a real bastard in my own right."

"Yeah? Well, you need to get your bastard ass over to me," Gale said. "I could be wrong, but I think I just found what we're looking for."

Before he'd even realized he was moving, Titan's hands had already formed fists. All that destruction. All those people hurt or worse. If he was mad, then Gale must be outright murderous. They had to pray she'd found the computer rather than the Super, otherwise no one would be able to stop her if she decided to take revenge.

"Did you find the computer or the guy who built it?" Titan asked, unclenching his fists so that he could cross his fingers.

"Both, I think. It's. . . well, it's pretty damn weird if you want the truth." The anger Titan had noticed in her earlier seemed to be ebbing, replaced with confusion. "I'd love some second opinions, especially from those of you who actually know something about tech."

"Great idea, but how do we get to you?" Deadlift asked.

"Using the communicators for coordinates, I believe I can offer rudimentary directions to Gale's location," Dispatch offered. "I have been mapping the facility as your teams progressed, and there are several areas where I suspect paths intersect. In the event I am incorrect, the barriers between hallways would be easily overcome, be it by strength or intangibility."

"Oh good, so I might have to punch through walls in an underground lair with who knows how much rock overhead. Nothing to worry about there." Despite his grumbling, Titan trusted Dispatch's judgment; there was really no other option as a Hero. And if Gale really had found something interesting, he wanted to get there as soon as possible.

“All right, Dispatch, tell us where to go.”

“I’ll be honest; I don’t have the damndest idea what I’m looking at here.” Titan didn’t particularly feel ashamed admitting that, both because he knew no one would be looking to him for technical expertise and because he had a solid hunch that he wasn’t the only baffled one in the group.

Getting to Gale had been relatively painless. Dispatch’s guesses were largely correct and Titan only had to punch carefully through one wall in order to keep him and Deadlift on the right path. Once they arrived, however, both strongmen immediately realized just how out of their depth they really were.

The contraption before them was massive, so tall it went halfway up the twenty-foot wall of this odd cavern, a mishmash of various electronics, lights, and devices that seemed to come from a half-dozen different technological periods. In the center was a modest-sized terminal with a dark screen directly adjacent to a large metal sphere with wires running all over the rest of the setup. It was the most striking point of the area in the first place, even without the corpse sitting in the chair.

“This is just a guess, mind you, but I’m going to say he’s been dead for at least months, probably years,” Aether announced. While Jeremiah was combing the wall of electronics, asking questions and getting unheard replies from the rest of his team, Aether had taken it upon herself to inspect the corpse hunched over in the chair. No one asked why she felt familiar enough with decomposing remains to inspect them, though most just chose to assume she had some medical background and leave it at that.

“No immediate wounds that I can see, which points toward natural causes, an internal attack like poison, or another Super. This place doesn’t have any signs of a struggle, but with how much work has been done, that doesn’t tell us anything for sure. We’ll need an autopsy to get solid information, but based on pure speculation, my guess would be that this guy sat down to do some work and then fell over dead midway through. Could be the ticker, or the noggin, or any other number of things, but something gave out on him.”

“You can tell that’s a guy?” Deadlift asked; the parts of his face that were visible under his mask had paled noticeably as Aether looked over the

corpse.

“Geez, it’s like none of you bothered to take a biology class. Yeah, I can tell it’s a guy. You want me to go into how?” Aether replied.

Deadlift shook his head adamantly to the negative. Aether didn’t push the issue, which Titan appreciated. There was already so little of his costume left, the last thing he wanted was to get the remainder sprayed with vomit if Deadlift lost his stomach.

Fortunately, the line of discussion quickly fell through as Jeremiah clapped his hands from over by the console.

“All right, people, based on what my team can tell me through the comms, though we absolutely need to have a tech-Super come check this out, all accounts point to us having found the heart of the operation. This is the thing that’s sending the signals, and most likely remotely handling all the mining and robot construction.”

“Then let’s tear it apart.” Gale summoned the beginnings of a tornado so quickly that the end of her sentence was muffled.

Jeremiah repositioned himself quickly between the terminal and Gale, a move Titan would have deemed brave if he didn’t know Jeremiah could heal from whatever wounds she inflicted.

“Yes, yes we could do that. Or we could just work on disconnecting it from all the remote operations until someone with tech-based abilities can come study it,” Jeremiah suggested. “As horrible as the robot attacks were, this still represents a marvel of technology. Look at the things it’s been creating, adapting, and improving, all without human interference. Hell, not half an hour ago it made a talking robot designed specifically to neutralize Titan, just based on the battles we had today. That is some astounding work, even more so now that we know there was no human behind the wheel.”

“All the better reason to destroy it now before it builds a threat we can’t handle.” Gale hadn’t dismissed her wind, a fact that escaped none of their attention. “Smart or not, this thing has been trying to wipe out us, and Brewster as a whole, for months.”

Titan was moving before he’d even realized it, Gale’s words stirring the memory of Hexcellent’s theory. The truth of the matter was, he agreed with Gale. Maybe this thing was a technological marvel unlike anything the world had ever seen, but it was also dangerous. He’d been forced to bring

down fellow humans who'd managed far less damage; a machine didn't get a pass for the carnage in its wake. Unless. . . it didn't know any better.

Before anyone could object, which they certainly would have, Titan moved the corpse away from the terminal, leaned over the ergonomic keyboard, and punched the space bar. For a long moment, nothing happened. Then, slowly, the dark screen began to flicker to life. At first, Titan didn't know what he was looking at; he'd never had much interest in the digital realm. Bit by bit, though, he puzzled together what he was seeing, and as it all clicked he shook his head in disbelief.

"I'll be damned. Hexcellent was right." Looking over his shoulder, he motioned for the others to come see the screen for themselves. "It's a game. A timed strategy or whatever. The map looks like Brewster, too. I think our dead programmer was playing it when he died, maybe trying to train the computer to do exactly what it did. Probably part one in a nefarious scheme where the rest was never hatched."

The rest of the group approached, taking in the display for themselves. It was all there, measured in bars and numbers that meant nothing to Titan. But some things were unmistakable: the map of Brewster, the six locations where the mechs had been deployed, even the little dots tracking the remaining Heroes that were helping secure damaged areas.

"Weird as this is, and I am definitely not saying it isn't strange, I don't see how it changes things," Gale told them. "This computer is still bent on wiping out our town. I say we carve it up now before it has a chance."

"Gale, with all respect, do you have any idea what we're looking at here?" Jeremiah asked. "This thing created its own troops, researched classified technology and stole it to improve them, adapted its designs and strategies based on how we reacted. . . it *learned*. I'm not the guy to say if something is or isn't artificial intelligence, but this has got to be the closest we've ever come as a species to creating it. You're talking about destroying one of the most incredible scientific achievements in history because some asshole left his game running."

"We've seen what it can do on accident. You really want to give someone the chance to use this thing on purpose?" Gale countered. "It's too strong, too dangerous. We have to destroy it now."

"You know, that's what a lot of humans said about Supers when they first learned about us." Aether's voice was quiet, yet strong enough to carry



through the whole cavern. “Something having the potential to be dangerous isn’t a good reason to kill it.”

“It’s not alive,” Gale shot back.

“Are you sure? I mean, really sure? I heard the robot Titan fought, and it sounded pretty aware of what was going on. Misinformed, yes, but aware,” Deadlift told her. “I’m not saying you’re wrong. In fact, I’m on your side, Gale. This thing nearly murdered me and my team with its robots, and it wrecked my town. It deserves to be killed. I’m just making sure we all acknowledge that that’s what we’re talking about. Killing.”

“Machines aren’t alive.” Gale didn’t sound as sure as she had moments prior, but she still refused to back down from her point.

“Two in favor of wrecking it here and now, two against,” Jeremiah summarized. “Titan, it looks like you’re the deciding vote.”

Slowly, Titan walked from the terminal over to the dense metal sphere. Even if he knew almost nothing about high-tech electronics, he’d set up enough lights and media centers in his day to understand that the device all the wires ran to was the most important part. It was the heart, or maybe the brain. Regardless, he was pretty sure that if he smashed it to pieces, that would be the end of their problems. Titan raised his hand over the device, only a few inches from the dark polished surface. It wouldn’t take much, one good blow and it would all be over.

“I think,” Titan said, slowly lowering his arm until his fingers rested against the smooth metal. “That everyone deserves a second chance. Potential artificial life included.”

## Epilogue

The restoration of Brewster would not be a quick process. Though the Heroes had performed admirably, containing the robotic threats and responding to unexpected challenges with speed and efficiency, the fact still remained that entire city blocks were rendered unlivable amidst the destruction. Within days, the DVA had set up temporary housing areas for those thrust from their homes. In a week, they'd brokered a deal between insurance companies and local hotels to get those impacted somewhere more stable. The first time a city was partially destroyed was a complete clusterfuck as everyone ran around, trying to figure out what to do. Nowadays, however, the DVA had the process down pat.

Not that their sole concern was taking care of the humans impacted by the disaster. One by one, every Hero in a command position at the scene was brought in for debriefing. While things could have been worse, it didn't change the fact that people had still died and millions of dollars in property damage had occurred. That was the sort of aftermath the DVA couldn't afford to shrug off and accept, meaning they went through the scenario with a fine-toothed comb, making certain that no Hero had acted rashly or used excessive force that might have exacerbated an already bad situation.

For his part, Owen's interview was mercifully brief. Though he had brought in a Temporarily Authorized Hero Asset and destroyed a mech with only one other Hero as backup, he'd also been careful to run things through Dispatch every chance he had. No one knew better than he that what the DVA wanted the most out of this was a scapegoat, someone or thing to point to as having failed. Their other option was telling the public that even with every Hero doing their job well, incidents like this could still happen. Although it was true, that wasn't the sort of truth that made for a happy populace. They needed their Heroes to be flawless, or to have the imperfect ones cast aside. But the DVA would have to search elsewhere for its sacrificial Super. Titan had played things careful and by the book, which Dispatch would back him up on.

Lenny was waiting for him as Owen left the meeting and immediately yanked off the blue tie that was too small for his thick, muscular neck. It looked all the more ridiculous atop his Titan costume, and Owen was glad to be rid of the idiotic formality. The short agent fell into line next to him as they

walked over the polished stone floor of Brewster City Hall. The DVA had set up temporary offices during the research and recovery efforts, partially to be seen around town doing their duty, and partially because it wasn't cost-effective to fly or teleport every Hero they wanted to interview off to D.C.

Neither said a word until they were clear of the building, at which point Lenny lifted his bushy eyebrows upward and cast a scrutinizing glance at his client.

"Well?"

"I'm clear," Owen replied, what should have been cheer in his voice soured by the experience of telling his tale while a panel sifted through every detail, searching for fault. "Unless they find something way out of left field that I'm not even aware of, nothing will blow back on me."

"That is quite the relief." Lenny dug about in his pockets until he found a pair of sunglasses that were comfortable, if not terribly up-to-date with the newest fashions. Overhead, the afternoon Brewster sun beat down on them, warming the prominent bald spot on Lenny's exposed head. "Let me tell you, with all the orders we've got coming in for Titan merchandise, the last thing I needed is you to be under investigation."

"I can't imagine that much is really moving," Owen said.

"Are you kidding me? Between the classic Titan gear, the new stylized versions, and that little photo of you going on everything from shirts to mugs, we've got suppliers dealing with serious backorders, and that's *after* I told them to stock up."

Owen suppressed a groan at Lenny's mention of the picture, but only barely. Evidently, amidst the brave reporters who'd ventured near the chaos of the battle was one especially intrepid photographer. That young woman was likely now a superstar at her paper, as she'd captured dozens of incredible images of the action in progress. One had especially caught on with the public, though. It was a picture of Titan as he'd lifted the mech overhead to save Hexcellent, though neither she nor Hopcules were easily visible in the shot. Instead, it just looked like he was hauling the thing up from the ground because he could, and while he wasn't especially fond of the attention the picture was garnering, he did have to admit it was a pretty incredible image. If nothing else, the world seemed to have suddenly remembered that on top of every scandal and rumor surrounding him, Titan was one thing above all else: powerful.

“At least that will give me some spare cash while I get things up and running. Any word yet on Hexcellent’s negotiations?” Owen asked.

Lenny nodded, yanking out the keys to his car and pressing a button to unlock the doors. “Word came down while you were inside. She’s going to have to buy out Mordent’s contract with her for the name and advertising rights to the Hexcellent brand and her original summons.”

“Those mother fuckers.” Owen spat the words, although he’d known going in that she was facing a tough battle.

“Hey, let me finish, all right?” Lenny and Owen both slipped into Lenny’s car. The passenger seat was already moved all the way back to somewhat accommodate Owen’s mighty frame. “She has to buy out the contract on all that, but the good news is she should have plenty of cash to do it with. Mordent only locked down the summons she had when she signed on, since no one expected her to be pulling out any new ones. They tried to pull some crap about Hopcules being preexisting, but in this case the contract fucked ‘em, since it outlined exactly what summons she had and their characteristics. Probably thought they were being slick by pinning her property down. Anyway, I tore that to shreds, and the arbiter agreed. Hexcellent has complete ownership of the Hopcules property and merchandising rights associated with it. Which, let me tell you, just from pre-orders looks like it will be more than enough to handle the Mordent contract.”

“Good.” Owen watched as Brewster City Hall faded into the distance and they began their trek to the next destination. “And I know I’ve said it before, but thanks for handling that.”

“Consider it a personal pleasure,” Lenny replied. “That Greene prick was fun to beat. Plus, it seems like I built up a little goodwill in the PEERS community. Already had three of the bigger names approach me about representation after they heard I’d taken on Bubble Bubble as a client.”

“The legendary Lenny, working with someone other than Heroes? Turn the car around, we need to go find some reporters and alert them to the news,” Owen said.

“There is always room at my table for anyone who earns,” Lenny replied, not a trace of shame in his voice. “So, where can I drop you?”

“Mordent Holdings’ central office,” Owen replied. “While I was in there, I got some news of my own, and I shouldn’t wait to share it with my team.”

\* \* \*

“Well well well, look who it is: the conquering Hero, come to pay us little people a visit?”

Despite the seemingly harsh words, Hexcellent barreled through the room and wrapped Owen in a giant hug as he entered the penthouse. In the chaos and fallout of the last week, he and the PEERS team had barely gotten to see one another. Except, of course, for when he stopped by to make the big announcement. They’d taken it well, all things considered. Deep down, he had a feeling they knew as much as he did that it was inevitable.

“I’ll have to speak to Greene about updating security. We can’t have any Tom, Dick, and Harry just wandering in here when they please.” Topsy hauled himself up from a chair in the kitchen and walked over, giving Owen’s hand a good shake. “It’s only been three days; did you need to check up on me already?”

“Maybe I came by to see if you needed advice,” Owen replied. “Hero Liaison isn’t the world’s easiest job.”

“Oh, I’m aware of that. We’ve been working nonstop with cleanup and rescue efforts. It’s enough to have an old Hero feel like he’s making a difference again.” Topsy released his grip as Galvanize, Zone, and Bubble Bubble all made their way over to greet and talk with their former Hero Liaison. There was no ill-will in the separation; they’d understood that he needed to be in a place where he could do the most with his abilities. Plus, Owen had left them in the most capable hands he knew of.

“What brings you by?” Galvanize asked, getting to the root of the visit as only a team leader could. “Don’t get me wrong, I’m glad to see you, but I assumed you’d be crazy busy getting everything up and running.”

“You’re not wrong,” Owen agreed. “But in the rush of handing things over to Topsy, there were a few items I left unfinished. Can’t very well go starting a new chapter in my life without wrapping up the old, now can I?”

“Uh oh, is this where you demand a match against all of us to see how much we’ve grown or something?” Bubble Bubble asked.

“No,” Owen replied. “This is where I give you each a proper goodbye. And I think you’re the best one to start with.” Owen scooped the pale, copper-haired woman up in a big bear hug, eliciting a squeal of surprised joy from the once-always-stoic Super. “I’m going to miss you, kid. Don’t go back into

that shell of yours 'cause I'm not on the team anymore, either. I'll be just down the road, and I can stop by anytime I want if needed. Also, try and keep away from dating directors."

"See, now where was that advice when I needed it?" Bubble Bubble asked, still grinning as Owen set her on the floor. Her expression grew confused as he produced a white card from his pocket and held it out to her, however. "What's this?"

"Parting gift, albeit a joint one. Lenny and I pulled some strings to set you up with a new image consultant. Given the ground work you laid during the director fiasco, and the eyes on the team after the attack, we thought it was time get you set up with someone who could help you sell the real you, not just whatever image some brand was pitching. Ludwig is among the best in the business."

Tentatively, she reached forward and plucked the card from his hand. "You're sure I can trust him?"

"Lenny says the guy is solid, and I trust Lenny with my life. More than that, I'd trust him with my family's lives. Nothing is guaranteed, but if it goes south then just let him or me know and we'll handle it," Owen assured her.

That done, he turned to Zone, who was actually looking at him rather than glaring, which was a marked improvement from when he'd first arrived.

"You still don't really like me, do you?"

"I'm not a fan of a lot of the choices you've made," Zone replied, his tone honest yet lacking any venom. "But it seems like you're trying to do your best to make amends. I can respect that much, at least. Just don't slack off. People are looking at you again. I hope you show them something worth seeing." Slowly, Zone extended his hand, and Owen accepted it. They were never going to be as close as he was with the others and both knew that. They'd reached a place of peace and mutual respect, though, and that counted for quite a bit in Owen's book.

"Thank you, Zone. I genuinely appreciate that. And I have something for you, though it won't arrive until later this week. I called in some old favors and there's going to be a healer dropping by. I think you've got a few good years left in you, so I want to get those knees taken care of," Owen said.

"That's a nice gesture, but healers can't fix the accumulated wear and

tear I put on my body; they just treat immediate injuries. Trust me, I looked into it.”

“Actually, that’s only true of *most* healers,” Topsy interjected. “If Titan is talking about the man I’m guessing, then he’ll have no trouble patching you up. Your knees— all of you, really—will be good as new.”

“And I want to give you this,” Owen added, pulling another card from his pocket before Zone could really wrap his head around what Topsy had said. When the reality of what Owen had given him truly sank in, it would likely be an emotional moment. Zone deserved the right to have that in private, if he so chose. “It’s a phone number where I can be reached, set to route through the DVA to reach me wherever I am. But it isn’t actually for you. It’s for your brother. Anytime he wants to talk, get some perspective, or even ask questions about what it takes to get into the Hero game, he can call me. If I can jump in this late in life, maybe he can too.”

Wordlessly, still reeling from the implication that his knees would be fixed, Zone accepted the card and held it between his fingers like it was made of glass. Owen turned away, letting Zone have space to process everything, and moving on to the leader of a team Owen had grown to respect immeasurably over the last few months.

“I really hope you didn’t get me anything,” Galvanize said, speaking before Owen had a chance. “It was gift enough having you on my team. Titan, you being around brought us all closer together, not to mention put us in the national spotlight more than once. You made my team better, and that’s all any PEERS leader could ask for.”

“Shit, kid, you really know how to steal someone’s thunder,” Owen told him. “As it happens, I don’t have a parting gift for you, but the DVA does. After seeing how much you helped during the attack, they want to put you on retainer for work as a Temporarily Authorized Hero Asset when the occasion is needed. The pay rate is decent, but more importantly, it should make sure you and your team keep getting the media exposure, even after the shitshow known as Titan is gone.”

Owen paused, taking in the younger man who’d shown such cool, smart judgment every step of the way in their time working together. Had he come onto another team with a different leader, this journey could have taken some very different turns. In a lot of ways, Owen owed more to Galvanize than anyone else, perhaps even Lenny. It was a debt he’d never really be able to clear, not that he wouldn’t try. Working toward the impossible was

becoming an oddly-familiar goal in his new life.

“I also want to say thanks. You made room for an out-of-practice Hero that was a media pariah and walked in thinking he was better than the job. In my years, I worked with a lot of folks who do incredible things. Still, you may be one of the most impressive people I’ve ever known, and being a Super has nothing to do with it.”

Owen and Galvanize shook hands one last time before Owen turned again. Though Hexcellent was next in line, he moved past her, meeting eyes with Topsy and pulling a folded set of pages from his back pocket.

“Parting gift for you, something to help round out the team,” Owen told his old friend.

Topsy accepted the pages and flipped through them, a look of cautious skepticism slowly appearing on his face. “You want me to recruit a criminal?”

“Eli’s a decent kid with a very useful power,” Owen replied. “Given his willingness to help me on the bridge the night he was arrested, and his cooperation during the robot attack, the DVA is considering letting him do community service as a PEERS to pay his debt to society. He’d need a Hero to take custody of him, though. Talk it over with Galvanize; see if you think he’s a good fit. I’ve got faith that whatever you two land on, it will be the right choice.”

That done, Owen finally faced Hexcellent once more. Though he’d bonded with the whole team to one extent or another, there was no denying that he and the tattooed young Super with dyed black hair had forged an especially close connection. Looking at her now, Owen found himself a bit regretful that his life had fallen apart before he managed to bring a daughter into the world. Of all the things he regretted from his years living a lie, his children were absolutely not among them.

“I know I already got my present,” Hexcellent said, preempting the announcement. “Lenny helping me negotiate ownership of my own image and summons was more than enough.”

“Well, you’re right and you’re wrong,” Owen told her. “That was the goodbye present, but there’s also something else for you. If you’re willing, why don’t you and I go for a ride?”

\* \* \*



From their vantage point, Hexcellent could just make out several people floating in the air, some in costumes and others wearing practical outfits designed for work. She and Owen were a ways off from the ravine with its secret base, which was the talk of Brewster as countless brave reporters tried to sneak close enough for a scoop only to be found and turned away. The official story on what had been found there was minimal, though that didn't stop all manner of rumor from swirling about.

"Show me what you've got." Owen stood near her, eyes never wavering as he waited for the demonstration to begin.

"Can I have a minute? My stomach is still fucking churning from that trip." Hexcellent had been surprised to discover that Owen's version of a 'ride' was running through town at top speed while she clung to his back for dear life. Though he'd kept a careful grip on her legs at all times, it hadn't made the journey any less terrifying. Or nauseating, for that matter.

"No one gives you time in the field. You have to be able to work under all sorts of conditions," Owen told her.

Hexcellent let out a few choice swears under her breath, but she also closed her eyes to focus. This was harder than her usual summons, the ones that sat so close to the top of her mind, bound to the milestones in her life that had shaped who she was. For this one, she had to go deeper, past the woman she'd become to the child she'd started out as. In a lot of ways, it was like distilling everything about her down to the purest, most innocent form. That was where her true guardian dwelled.

A pop filled the air, and next to Hexcellent stood a three-foot-tall rabbit on its hind legs, wearing a colorful suit of armor. It looked from her to Owen several times, then leaned its head against the summoner's leg in a nuzzling motion.

"Damn, that is beyond adorable." Owen shook his head; he couldn't even imagine how many of these things would be on the shelves come next Christmas, to say nothing of the more intimidating versions still showing up on news reports. "Not quite as potent, though."

"Yeah, well, I'm not really all that scared right now, am I?" Hexcellent countered. "I talked to some of those DVA guys and the Heroes who debriefed me: the running theory is that he came out so strong because I was fuckall terrified. No threat means he's the old-fashioned fluffy version."

"That's what I'd heard too," Owen said. Determining a Super's

abilities was often a game of elimination, creating and discarding theories until one finally seemed to fit. In Hexcellent's case, they'd had very little to go on and an inversely large motivation to understand what made her summon tick. An adaptive rabbit that could grow twenty-stories-tall when the need arose wasn't the sort of power they'd want to let run loose without knowing how it worked.

"Kind of too bad, when you think about it." Owen sat down in the grass, watching the floating Supers in the distance as they ensured none of the workers in the ravine were disturbed. "With the PEERS gig, the fluffy guy won't have too many chances to really flex his stuff. Only so much call for an unstoppable bunny in rescue work."

"Never know, the little bastard might find his time to shine." Hexcellent rubbed Hopcules between the ears as she also took a seat on the ground. It was nice: out here away from the city's center, she could almost forget about all the destruction and work that awaited them back in Brewster. "And even if he doesn't, at least we got one hell of a chance to live the dream. Thanks for that, by the way. I never thought I'd actually get to play Hero, but because of you, I did. Even if it was just for an hour, that time meant more to me than I ever realized it would."

"Glad to hear that," Owen said. "Because if you're up to the challenge, you might be able to have that experience again." Reaching into his back pocket, he pulled forth the last of his documents and handed it to Hexcellent, who unfolded the page and began slowly reading.

Owen was silent as she absorbed the words; something like this might take a few minutes to wrap her head around. That was why he'd taken her out here, where the world was more peaceful. That, and in case Hopcules had come out in his big form once more.

"I don't understand," Hexcellent finally said. "I mean, I know this is an acceptance letter, but. . . I didn't even apply."

"The dean of Sizemore and I are on good terms," Owen explained. "We sat down and had a long talk about you. About your past, about you cleaning yourself up and giving back to the community, about who you were under the makeup. Dean Jackson is a hard man with some patience issues, but he's also the type who believes people can change. With my recommendation, he agreed to accept you into next year's freshman HCP class. That's why I gave Topsy the folder on Eli, so he can serve as a potential replacement. The spot in Sizemore is yours, if you want it."

The paper in her hands was shaking, and wordlessly Hopcules wrapped his furry arms around Hexcellent's torso. "You're serious? This. . . this is real? I can be a Hero?"

"That's up to you," Owen said. "Getting in the HCP is a lot easier than staying there, and few Supers ever reach graduation. Make no mistake, you'll have to prove that you belong there every day, or you'll be cast out like so many before you. But if you can do the near-impossible, then yes, Hexcellent. You can be a Hero one day. This time, for real."

She was hugging him before he even noticed her move, tears running across his shirt where Hexcellent's face was pressed into his shoulder. For once, this was a costume cleaning that he wouldn't complain about.

"Titan. . . thank you so much. There's no way I can really do this though, is there? I'm already past college age, and my face is all over the place in advertisements. Even I know Heroes have to keep their identity secret."

Gently, noting the wary eyes of Hopcules, Owen rested his hand on top of her ink-black hair. "You only have to keep it secret as a student; after that it's a choice. Don't worry about your age either; lots of people do college later in life. Hell, if anything it makes you less likely to be suspected of being in the HCP. As for the face, as long as you cut back on the makeup, switch hair-dyes, and cover the tattoos, I think you'll be unrecognizable. No one is going to hunt that hard for a corpie that left her team."

"Except that I summoned a giant rabbit that half the town is talking about," Hexcellent reminded him.

"About that: you may have noticed that the rabbit is all they're talking about. No one got a good picture of the woman riding its shoulder, and the DVA is holding back that information pending your acceptance. So far as the world is concerned, Hexcellent was just the goth PEERS that summoned demons. The only people who know the truth are Mordent, who are too smart to break a DVA gag order, other Heroes, and your teammates. If you want, we can let the news out. You'll probably be the most popular PEERS in the country overnight. Or the DVA can designate the situation as classified, and you become a nobody freshman in the HCP next fall and tackle the PEERS past if you make graduation. It's all up to you, Hexcellent."

"Hannah." Slowly, she lifted her head from his shoulder, though the tears were still falling freely. Her dark makeup was streaked and smudged,

already fading to show the woman who dwelled underneath. “Can’t very well go by my old corpie name at school, now can I?”

“No, I suppose not.” Owen leaned forward a bit, meeting the glassy-eyed stare of her guardian rabbit. “You and the others are going to need to take care of her from this point on. She’ll be plenty scared more than once working through the Hero Certification Program.”

Hopcules nodded, and though it might have been Owen’s imagination, he thought he saw the barest traces of claws peeking out from Hopcules’s fuzzy fingers.

“Good rabbit.”

\* \* \*

Once she’d regained her composure, Owen dropped Hexcellent, Hannah, off at the hotel lobby where an older, seemingly-innocuous man was waiting to discuss the details of her enrollment. Dean Jackson would bring her the rest of the way up to speed, making sure she truly understood what she was facing if she chose to attend Sizemore. He’d probably try to scare her off, at least a bit, as the program had little time to waste with those that couldn’t handle the harsh reality of what they were undertaking. The effort would fail, though, of that Owen had zero doubt. He’d seen the bravery and determination in that girl’s soul. Now that she had a real shot at her dream, nothing would make her turn away.

With his former team seen to, the time had come for Owen to look ahead.

Bounding through town, he ran to the abandoned district where the team once known as the Wild Bucks made their home. Juiced and Kaiju were both in the gym area, working hard just as they had been when he last saw them. Neither had been seriously injured in the battle with the robots, though both had seen the limits of their abilities more than once. For some Supers, not being powerful enough when it counted destroyed them, shook their confidence and drove them away from future confrontations. Heroes, however, were made of sterner stuff. At least, the ones Owen respected were. When they failed, it lit a fire under them to become better, stronger, more capable for the next time around. And it reminded them that no Super was unstoppable alone. Trusting their team was more important than any individual ability.

Sometimes, even Owen needed to be reminded of that.

Deadlift was in the makeshift office, reviewing documents. He glanced up at the massive form of Owen as it entered, shaking his head in annoyance. "You sure you don't want to take over the leadership position here? I figured when you asked to join I'd at least be free of the paperwork. I mean, you are the most experienced Hero on the team."

"And with experience comes wisdom, such as knowing that being a leader means having to deal with the boring crap like paperwork," Owen countered. "Besides, I think you've got this well in hand. I'm good at hitting stuff; you handle things like tactics and planning."

Although there had been no shortage of teams offering Titan spots when the robot battle dust settled, Owen had decided to throw in with Deadlift and his crew. In part it was because he needed someone he trusted looking after the PEERS, and Topsy wouldn't budge until his people were taken care of. But more than that, Owen wanted to be there because he knew how precarious their position still was. This was a team that deserved to exist, and if his presence could help them stay afloat, then it was a worthwhile endeavor. Besides, there was something he just liked about being back in these barebones quarters; it reminded him of his early days, before the press and the merchandising and the attention. Back when it was all about the job and the people in the trenches with him.

"Well, the good news is that we just got word from the DVA, and the name change is officially approved," Deadlift told him, setting down a crisp page atop his desk. "All it needs is your signature. But I do have to ask, for the umpteenth time, are you really okay with letting us have this? It's a strong legacy, and I hate the idea that we might tarnish it."

Owen leaned forward, grabbing the paper and a pen that that seemed downright dainty in his oversized hand and scrawling "Titan" across the blanks Deadlift had marked. "Maybe we'll drag the name down; maybe we'll raise it to new heights. Doesn't matter either way. It wasn't doing anyone any good just sitting there in the history books. But you all had to chuck the Wild Bucks; that was a reputation that needed to be abandoned. If your lot wants to resurrect this antique, I'm not going to be the one to stop you."

With a final signature, Owen pushed the page back over to Deadlift, who examined it carefully. He doubled-checked each line to be sure everything was in order, just like a good leader should. Owen had high hopes for this kid, as well as for Juiced and Kaiju. That was why he'd refused to take over as head of the team. One day, Deadlift was going to an incredible

Hero and a respected leader, but he needed experience to get there. Owen's job was to guide the next generation, not take over for them.

"As far as I can tell, this is all in order," Deadlift said. "Once I send a copy to the DVA, the Gentle Hammers will officially live again. I still can't believe you got all of the old team to sign off on letting us use the name, though."

"You do Hero work with someone long enough, there's not much you won't trust each other with," Owen replied. "And truth be told, I don't think any of them were happy with how that legacy ended, a bunch of people just drifting apart. Win, lose, or draw, at least this gives the Gentle Hammers a chance for a new ending."

"On that note, we're being tapped for patrol duty tonight," Deadlift told him. "There's been some increased crime and looting in the wrecked sections of town, so Heroes are being rotated around to keep the peace. So try to hurry back."

"Who said I was going anywhere?" Owen asked.

To that, Deadlift replied with a sarcastic laugh. "Come on, we both know you're only here checking in. In an hour you'll be out the door again, going to the same place you've spent every spare moment you could for the last week. Just be back by eight, our patrol run starts at nine."

"Yes, sir." Owen rose from his chair and snapped off a crisp salute. They both knew he'd be back by the deadline. This was his team, and when they went out, they'd do so with Titan to watch over them.

"Oh, and give Jeremiah my best," Deadlift called after him as Owen left the office.

\* \* \*

Moving the massive device had been no small task, although having several Supers with tech-based abilities made it far easier. The biggest concern, of course, was that unplugging the wrong wire might do irreparable damage to a wholly unique piece of technology. Thanks to a lot of effort, portable generators, and more than one teleporter working in tandem, they'd managed to get the wall-sized computer out from the hidden lair and in to a privately-owned storage building, one carefully cut off from all wireless signals the computer might use to begin causing trouble again.

Owen had to surrender his cell phone as he entered the building, handing it off to a squad of DVA agents carefully guarding the door. They were there to handle the mundane stuff, ensuring that no one accidentally brought high-tech devices inside. So far as anyone knew, the computer had to be hardwired to connect to other systems, but no one was willing to take a chance on being wrong. Especially not at the rate at which it seemed to be learning.

Several Heroes were present inside the central area, along with a few Supers and tech-savvy people brought in as DVA contractors. Most of them Owen didn't recognize, though given how far apart their fields of specialty were from his own, that wasn't too surprising. Allegedly, Modus Operandi was heading up the investigation and assessment, though Jeremiah seemed to be the only one who was on site. Even Gale stopped by more often than they did, in what she called 'due diligence' to ensure nothing got out of hand. Perhaps to make up for his team, Jeremiah was always there, and as Owen stepped through the entry station, today proved no different. The Subtlety Hero was watching over a crew of workers while they catalogued every bit of the device down to the screws.

"Has anyone figured out for sure if this thing is alive or not yet?" Owen asked. It was the burning question on everyone's minds, and while some had made declarations already, no one had conclusively proved their point one way or the other.

"You don't really need me to tell you that determining sentience is a long, inexact art again, do you?" Jeremiah replied. He didn't seem tired in the slightest, despite having been awake since they'd infiltrated the base. Owen wasn't even sure Jeremiah needed to sleep, given the way his power worked. It was an ability that seemed exceedingly simple, yet upon inspection was complex and multi-faceted. Not unlike its owner, actually.

"I keep hoping one of these smart people will figure it out." Owen nodded to the array of techs combing through the device, paying special attention to the one sitting at the terminal. "How about the guy typing? He made any headway?"

"Loads," Jeremiah said. "This thing can learn at a remarkable rate and adapt on the fly. We've already gotten it to understand that the game it thought it was playing was real, and that the deaths it caused were not digital."

"Was it remorseful?"

“It assimilated the information and then spat out an apology.” Jeremiah slowly rubbed his temples, as though a headache were coming on. “Some wanted to use that as proof of intelligence, while others thought it was just a very sophisticated program replying the way it was designed to when an error was pointed out. Hand to god, every hour I spend watching these people bicker makes me wish a little more that I’d had you smash the thing.”

“Something tells me that tune will change if they officially declare it to be AI,” Owen countered.

“A big if, at least from where we are now.” Jeremiah let his hands fall away and looked at Owen with a long gaze. “Hey, you want to go get something to eat? I’ve been on duty here for days; it’s time for someone else to pick up the slack.”

“I’ve got a few hours until I’m on patrol, getting some food might not be the worst idea.” Owen checked his watch, a battered old analog model that still barely passed the entrance tech-inspection. “Food truck?”

“Quaint as that is, I was thinking something a little nicer. I could pull some strings and get us a table at a lovely little bistro downtown,” Jeremiah offered.

Owen slowly lowered his hand, noticing for the first time the mischievous glint in Jeremiah’s eyes. “Sounds pretty fancy for just grabbing a meal.”

“If one must eat, one should do it well,” Jeremiah said. “And besides, I did say that I’d ask you on a proper date eventually. Things are calm for now, so it seems like as good a chance as any.”

Although he’d known in the back of his head this was coming, Owen was still taken by surprise at the declaration. The way Jeremiah could be so cavalier and open about these things was still foreign to Owen, and in truth, it was something he admired about his fellow Hero. In spite of how he’d seemed in their first impression, Jeremiah did have some worthwhile traits, not the least of which was the fact that he was one of the few other Supers that had an unnatural relationship with the aging process. He was someone who didn’t need protecting, someone who had a set of skills entirely apart from what Owen could do, and that was intriguing.

Besides, it was just dinner. Maybe it would be wonderful. Maybe it would be a disaster. But things would happen, and Owen would move forward. He’d put himself on ice over a decade ago when a choice of passion



had brought the world he'd so carefully constructed crumbling down around him. Ten years plus was long enough. It was time to get the rest of his life moving again, and Jeremiah was at least a first step with whom he had the job in common.

"Get us a reservation for tomorrow," Owen told him. "If we're going out, then we'll do it right, not with a quick meal before I have to run off for patrol."

It was Jeremiah's turn to be surprised, arching a single eyebrow upward. "I'm glad to have you accept, though I must say I thought it would be more difficult. Finally giving in to my irresistible charm?"

"Don't push your luck," Owen advised him. "I just decided to try something new. We can always call it off if you get too annoying."

Jeremiah held up his right hand with the palm facing Owen. "I shall be on my best behavior. Scout's honor. Well, Hero's honor; I didn't fare so well in the scouts. Guess this means I don't have to use the gift I had planned to soften you up with. It can just be a token of my esteem." From one of the many pockets on his costume, Jeremiah produced a small card with a phone number penned across the clean white surface. "Friend of mine who graduated from Lander a few years back. I know you've been angling to get a seat at their end-of-year exams; she's someone who can get things moving."

Owen accepted the card, turning it over once and committing the number to memory, just in case. "How many favors you think she'll pull out of me?"

"It won't be cheap, but shouldn't cost you an inordinate amount of your time, either," Jeremiah replied. "Though I am curious why you're keen on peeking in on an HCP class."

"Maybe I'm looking to take an intern." While that was a ruse to keep Jeremiah's curiosity at bay, the idea actually didn't seem intolerable as Owen considered it. He was already taking younger Supers under his wing; perhaps he'd try the role in an official capacity. Roy and Hershel would almost certainly refuse, but there were rumors that Lander's juniors had more than a few heavy-hitters. Owen might see for himself, assuming he could pull enough strings to get in the door for their end-of-year exam. That would be a vacation to look forward to, one he'd earn after several more months of hard work.

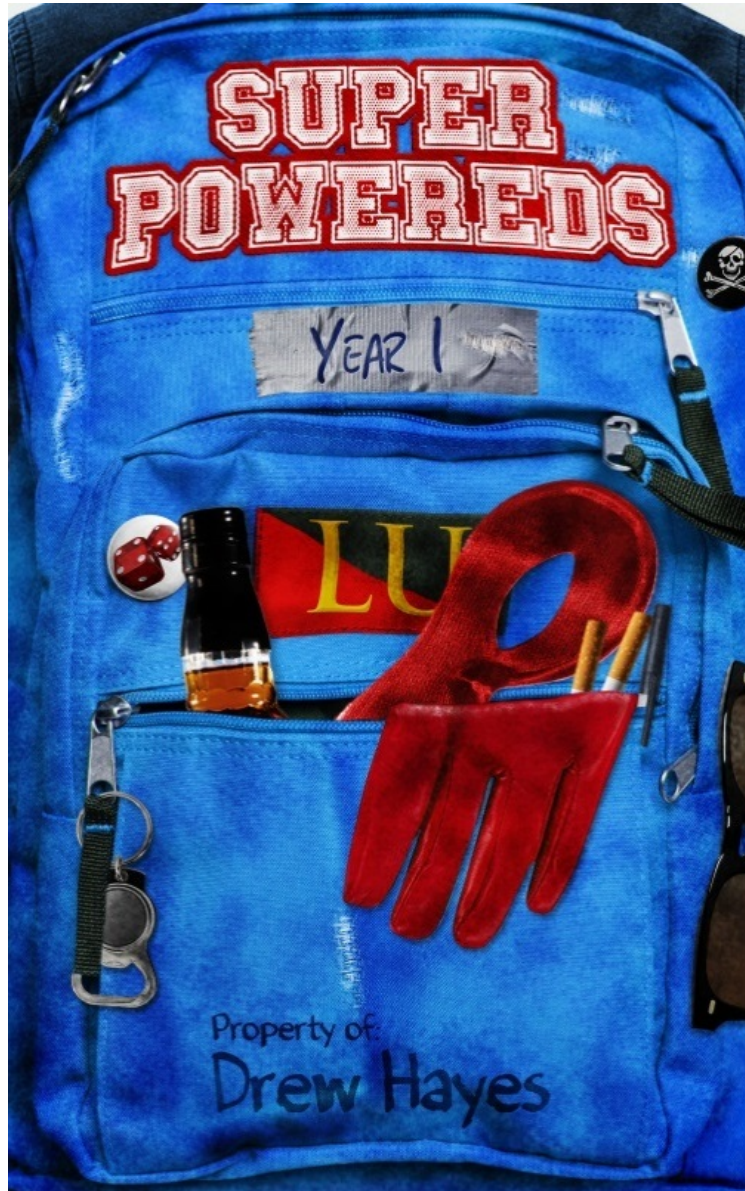
"About dinner," Owen said, tucking the card into his pocket.

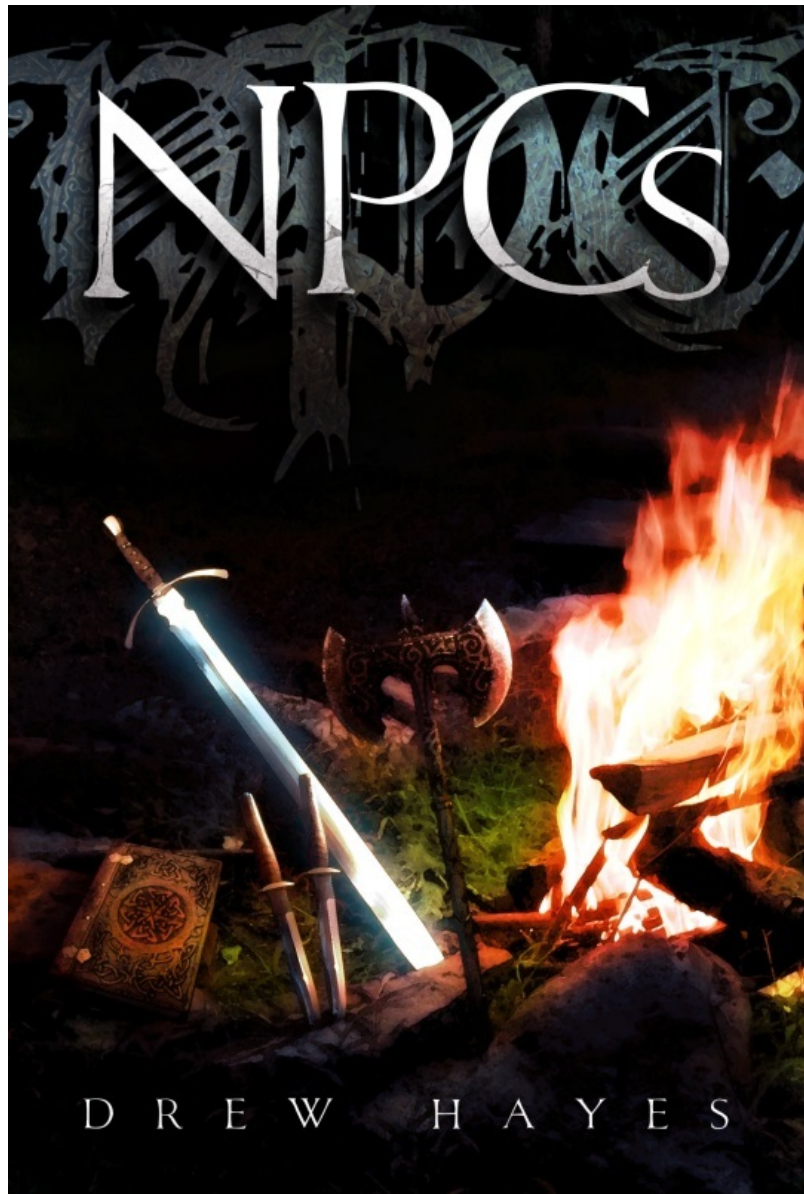
“Nowhere too fancy. I’m not a tablecloth and place setting kind of guy. Since you asked, you can pick, but my rules are that it has to have good food, good beer, and not ask for anything fancier than blue jeans.”

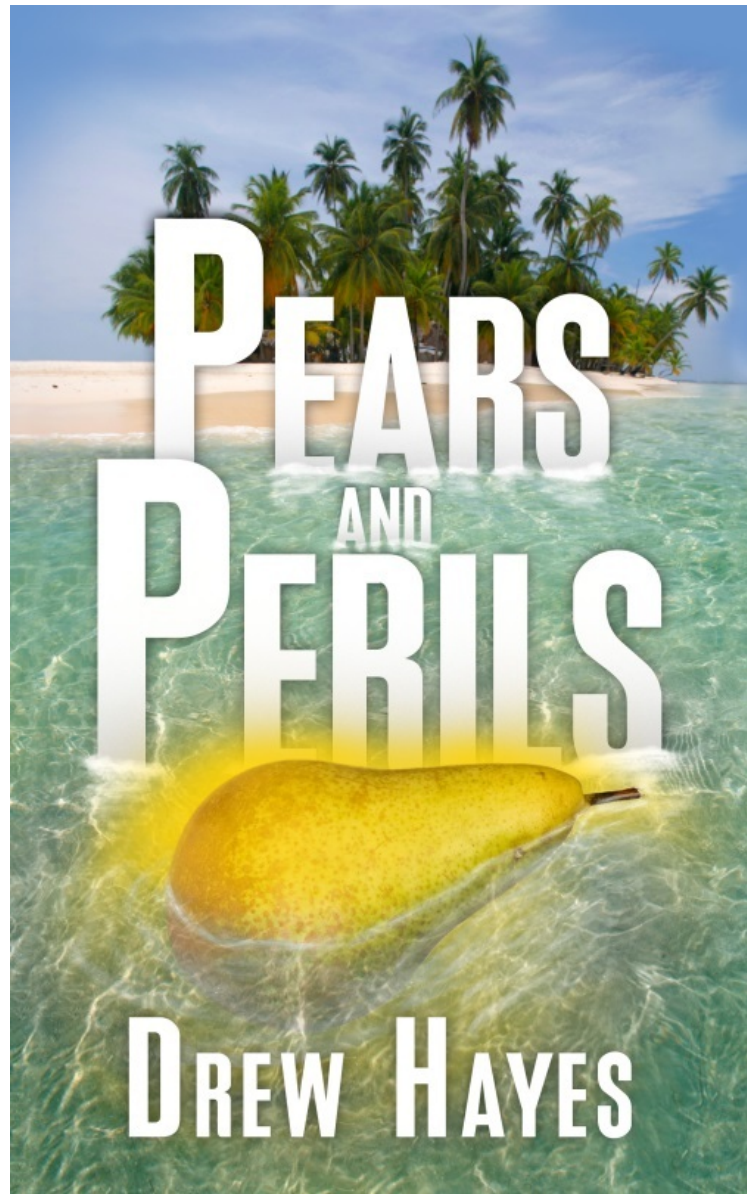
“You are really putting me to the test, aren’t you?” Jeremiah let out a heavy sigh, though he didn’t look quite as downtrodden as the tone made him out to be. “I’ll rise to the challenge and find a suitable establishment, though, of that have no doubt. I suppose it’s a good thing you’re giving me the extra day, all things considered. Pity nonetheless; I was hoping to start the date as soon as possible.”

“Good thing you’re such a resilient guy. Something tells me you’ll live with the disappointment,” Owen said. “Now if you’ll excuse me, I need to go get a briefing from these eggheads and then head back out to downtown. There’s a lot of work to do, and I’ll be damned if Titan is going to miss any more of it.”

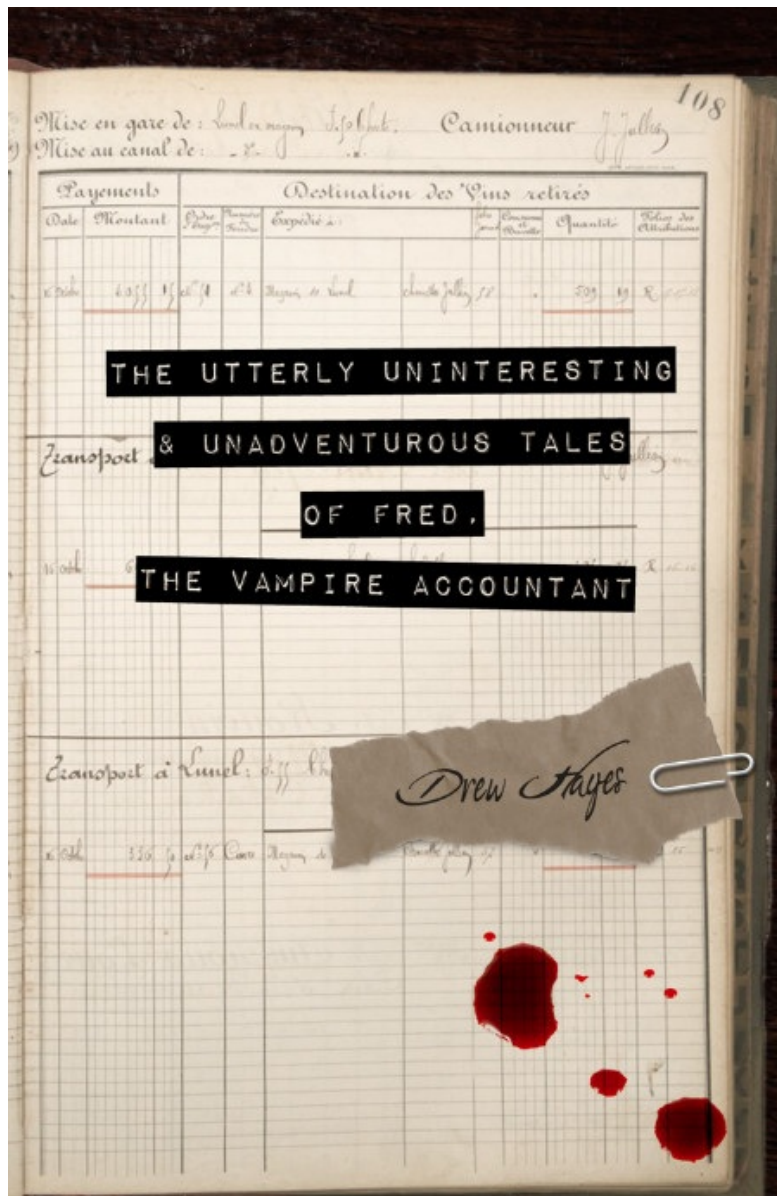
## Other Novels by Drew Hayes











## About the Author



Drew Hayes is an author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does

appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

Read or purchase more of his work at his site: [DrewHayesNovels.com](http://DrewHayesNovels.com)



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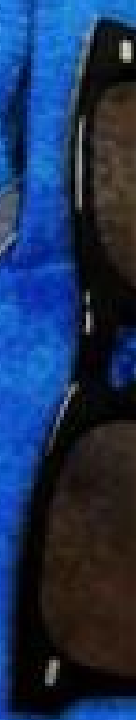
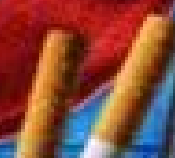
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# SUPER POWEREDS

YEAR 1



Property of  
Drew Hayes

# **Super Powered: Year 1**

By Drew Hayes

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# Foreword

(AKA: Skip this and the book will implode)

Okay, fine, so the book won't really implode. Well, probably. On second thought, I'm not going to make you any promises on what will or will not happen. However, I did want to draw your attention to these short paragraphs in order to explain the sizable length and chapter count of this novel.

Super Poweredreds began three years ago as a Webnovel over at my site: [drewhayes.digitalnovelists.com](http://drewhayes.digitalnovelists.com). It is the first book in a series of four, and it was published chapter by chapter over the course of a year and a half. This explains the sheer number of chapters that are, admittedly, individually a bit shorter than what one would see in a classic novel. I debated rearranging them for this e-book; however, the chapter breaks often represented natural breaking points in the story, so in the end I decided better to be a little odd than risk wrecking the book's flow.

I'll keep the rest of this short and sweet, since I know as well as anyone that so few people read the forewords. Thank you for purchasing (or sampling) this novel. It is the culmination of years of work, none of which would have been possible without the wonderful readers who offered me endless encouragement throughout the process. I sincerely hope you enjoy it, so I'll stop yammering and let you get on to reading.

## Prologue

The two well-dressed men materialized outside of a small white brick building. The taller of the two pulled out a miniature notepad, made an entry with the slash of a few pen strokes, and then stowed it away once more.

“Where are we, Mr. Transport?” The speaker was the shorter man, wearing a black suit with a black tie and presently putting on a pair of black sunglasses to fight back the sun’s penetrating glare.

“Arizona, Mr. Numbers,” replied the taller man, who by elimination could only be Mr. Transport, as he adjusted the sunglasses he had put on before they departed.

“I was under the impression our next case was in Colorado,” commented Mr. Numbers.

“He was; however, there was an incident last week. Circumstances required he be moved to a location able to accommodate his specific needs.”

“I see,” said Mr. Numbers. With that, the two of them walked around to the front of the building and proceeded inward. They were stopped as soon as they entered, not by the expected, poorly-paid security guard, but rather by an elderly man wearing a white lab coat.

“Good morning, gentlemen. I’ve been expecting you,” said the white-coated man. “My name is Dr. Hubert.”

Mr. Numbers cocked his eyebrow slightly and Mr. Transport replied with an almost imperceptible nod. This exchange took the place of the relevant conversation, which would consist of Mr. Numbers asking if the name and the call ahead had checked out and Mr. Transport reporting that it had. This method was more efficient, though, and had the added benefit of allowing the duo to take people by surprise when things were not quite so congruent.

“We’d like to see the boy,” said Mr. Numbers.

“Of course you would,” Dr. Hubert agreed. “However, first I’d afraid I must ask you to take off anything electrical. Watches, phones, anything with a battery must go. I do hope neither of you has a pacemaker.”

Neither Mr. Numbers nor Mr. Transport had pacemakers. They did both carry expensive, high-powered phones, though, as well as top-of-the-line watches, and a pair of taser guns. All of these were deposited into a small safe



in the front lobby area with Dr. Hubert's adamant assurances that everything would be returned once they were done. Neither Mr. Numbers nor Mr. Transport showed any concern about the safety of their valuables.

Once that was completed, Dr. Hubert pulled out a small candle and lit it, then repeated the procedure twice more until all three men were equipped with a diminutive wax lighting instrument. Dr. Hubert kept expecting one of the men to ask why they had shed their electronics and were being handed candles in the middle of the day. They did not.

Dr. Hubert led them through the doors of the lobby, into a dimly-lit hallway covered in green tile. They made their way down it, coming to a solid steel door at the end. Dr. Hubert made a quick series of punches on the keypad and the door released, opening to reveal total darkness. As the trio stepped through, the door shut behind them, leaving them with only their candles to see by. Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport paused to remove their sunglasses.

Their eyes adjusted and they realized they had stepped into another hallway, this one formed of solid concrete. There were no doors to their sides, only another metal one at the end of the hallway. Dr. Hubert began the walk down, moving more briskly than he had before. Mr. Numbers observed that the deeper into this place they went, the more nervous Dr. Hubert became. He filed that away, and then began following a few paces behind.

They made their way down the hallway without incident then stepped through the next metal door. Inside was what looked like a large concrete bunker with a sizable glass window peering into the next room. Though both strained, they could not make out anything in the pitch black on the other side of the glass.

"He's normally more stable than this," Dr. Hubert said. "But unfortunately a few days ago he was trying to fix his toaster and he received a nasty electrical shock."

"Ah," said Mr. Numbers. "So that's why a quarter of Colorado lost power last week."

"Yes," admitted Dr. Hubert. "Before he was able to sever the connection he had drained his own city's power supply, along with that of all the areas surrounding it. We're trying to help him burn off all that electricity, but it comes in spurts and is almost impossible to predict."

"I see," said Mr. Transport.

"It's also affecting his natural abilities," continued Dr. Hubert. "That's

why I had you remove all electrical devices and why we are keeping him out of the sunlight. He's been pulling from anything that gets even remotely close to him."

As if on cue, Mr. Number's candle jerked violently in the direction of the window and went dark.

"I'm sorry he's not more stable today," Dr. Hubert apologized again.

"If he were, he wouldn't be in consideration for our program anyway," said Mr. Numbers, eyes still trained on his own dark candle.

"Oh, does that mean you're still counting him as a possibility?" Dr. Hubert asked.

"There will be some preliminary testing and an interview process," said Mr. Transport. "But if I were to offer my opinion, I would say we have a very viable candidate on the other side of that glass."

\* \* \*

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport next materialized before a hospital in Nevada. Mr. Transport again produced his notepad, jotted down a few scribbles, and then put it back where it belonged.

"Another incident?" Mr. Numbers asked.

"Par for the course with this one, to my understanding," replied Mr. Transport.

The duo then entered the hospital. They spoke briefly to a nurse, producing badges that rendered her silent, procured the information they needed, and then headed upstairs. It was something of a walk to get where they were heading, and by the time they were done, they had crossed out of the main hospital into a more run-down attachment wing. The doctors here were fewer and more haggard, and the walls looked worn-down and repainted. Hospitals were never what Mr. Transport thought of as cheerful, but this area was enough to inspire one to end it all. Which very well might have been the point.

Mr. Numbers stopped at the appropriate room and the two entered. It was like the rest of the wing: worn-down, beat-up, and hopeless. This one had two unique additions, though: a young man lying in a hospital bed and a recently-exploded television that was still smoking.

"Mr. Campbell," greeted Mr. Transport. "A pleasure to meet you."

“Call me Nick,” said the boy. He spoke with an easy tone that matched his overly-relaxed appearance. Despite the mandatory hospital gown, he had still taken the time to gel his thick hair. “And I take it you two are my interview committee?”

“Indeed,” confirmed Mr. Transport. “What happened to the television?”

“Beats me. I went to turn the thing on and I guess the tubes overloaded or something,” answered Nick.

“I see,” said Mr. Transport skeptically.

Mr. Numbers had been browsing through Nick’s chart during the exchange with Mr. Transport and chose this time to jump in. “So, according to the records, you won a ten thousand dollar scratch-off ticket, after which you were hit by a bus while celebrating in the street, which knocked you into a bounce house that had been set up nearby, a bounce house whose motor had the poor timing to overload and explode after your impact. Do I have everything correct?”

“You might want to tack on that my winnings just covered my hospital bill and damages owed to the bounce house owner,” Nick added.

“You were held accountable for the damages,” Mr. Transport said. It wasn’t a question, but Nick chose to take it as one anyway.

“Well, you know how it is. People tend to blame my kind first and ask questions later,” Nick said, not quite managing to mask the bitterness in his voice.

“We know, Mr. Campbell,” said Mr. Numbers. “That’s exactly what brought us here today.”

Mr. Transport walked over to the room’s entrance and shut the door firmly.

\* \* \*

The two next appeared in a forest. This wasn’t a forest in the sense of parks that can seem sprawling or a cluster of spruces that can form on the side of an untended highway. This was a forest in an ancient and powerful sense, with trees that were massive and served as ecosystems within their ecosystem. This was a place untouched and unaware of all the progress *Homo sapiens* had made with their pitiful time upon the earth. Untouched, that is, with the exception of the trailer a few feet away from Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport.

Sitting in a rocking chair, sipping a glass of lemonade, was a young girl whose file said seventeen but whose face said fourteen. She was wiry and lean, with short hair that poked up in several different directions. She stared at the two of them unblinkingly, and the two stared right back at her.

The three of them stood in silence for several minutes like that, the girl's eyes flitting between the two of them, theirs remaining constant on her. At last the girl took a long sip of her lemonade and said out loud, "That sounds lovely."

A simultaneous nod came from Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport, and then they were gone.

\* \* \*

"Hershel! Come downstairs. The nice men are here to see you." The speaker was a dowdy woman in her fifties who was setting down a kettle and cups in front of Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport. "Are you sure I can't get you gentlemen anything to eat?"

"Thank you, Ms. Daniels, but we are quite comfortable," said Mr. Numbers.

"Oh, no need for that, please call me Sally," Ms. Daniels replied, her eyes lingering on Mr. Numbers and the strong figure housed beneath the covering of his black suit.

"Good morrow, my men," said Hershel as he descended the stairs into the yellow-painted kitchen. Hershel was a portly young man, long dirty blond hair dribbling down to his chin and a forest-green shirt underneath the rich royal-purple of his cape.

"Why are you wearing a cape?" Mr. Transport was unable to suppress his own curiosity.

"It's a cloak," Hershel corrected. "After we partake in a large lunch, my men and I are taking the castle up at Rothring Ring peak and doing battle with a foul vampire lord."

"My little Hershel is a bit overly creative," Ms. Daniels commented. "He and his friends are active in the community's live action role playing club."

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport exchanged a look. There is no need for clarification on the meaning of this one.

"Well, we don't want to keep you," Mr. Numbers said honestly.

“However, we were hoping to speak with Roy, if that’s at all possible.”

“Oh,” said Hershel, disappointment sweeping across his face. “Of course; everyone wants to talk to Roy.”

“It’s just that we have some things to discuss with him,” Mr. Numbers attempted to clarify.

“I’m sorry,” Hershel said. “I don’t think he’ll be around today. He went to a country bar last night and... well, he usually doesn’t show up for a while after uproars like that.”

“Ah,” said Mr. Transport. “That does explain the cleanup crew that was dispatched this morning.” Mr. Numbers shot Mr. Transport a look, but Mr. Transport merely shrugged, as if to say he didn’t find it to be of any importance.

“If that’s the case then we will be on our way,” said Mr. Numbers. “I don’t want to keep you from your... activities. We will need to speak with Roy at a later date.”

“Wait,” Hershel said, jumping to his feet. “I know what you’re here about, and I really want to get in. I’m tired of living like this. Never knowing when it will happen, never knowing where I’ll wake up. Please, if you can really help me control it... Please don’t leave.”

“It’s okay, Hershel,” Mr. Transport said as he patted the large boy on his shoulder. “We aren’t giving up on you just because of a reschedule. You’re a serious candidate for our program. I promise we’ll be back once we can talk to Roy as well.”

Hershel nodded his understanding, and then turned away quickly so the two men wouldn’t see the tears forming in his eyes. He didn’t know what his chances were at the moment, but he was smart enough to guess that crying in front of the agents wouldn’t help things.

Mr. Numbers tapped impatiently on Mr. Transport’s shoulder and gestured to his watch. Mr. Transport nodded, and then turned his head to Ms. Daniels.

“Thank you for the tea,” said Mr. Transport just before they vanished.

\* \* \*

The duo appeared in a sprawling garden, under a gazebo and next to a pair of wicker chairs. There was a small serving cart on the far side of a stone table. Sitting next to the cart and sipping on a cocktail was a man. He wore a

white open-throated shirt and a pair of khakis. This man was getting on in years but wearing them unbelievably well. It's not that the signs of age weren't present, but rather that they served to draw out and enhance his fine features rather than muddle them.

"I'm glad you could make it," greeted the man in a voice that made clear, without apology, that he had never considered their presence optional.

"Our pleasure, Mr. Adair," Mr. Numbers said hurriedly. For the first time all day, for the first time in years really, the pair was showing signs of nervousness. They had been told of their required presence for this meeting, but not about the subject matter that it concerned. That left both of them feeling something they were not accustomed to: vulnerable.

"Sit, sit," said Mr. Adair. "Can I get you something to drink?"

"I'd like a gin and tonic, if it's no trouble, sir," said Mr. Transport. This was their final meeting of the day, so Mr. Transport didn't see the harm in indulging just a bit.

"Just water for me, thanks," said Mr. Numbers. Mr. Numbers was already writing out the riot act he was going to read Mr. Transport for asking for alcohol while on the job, but facially he was working hard to keep everything upbeat and positive.

Mr. Adair pulled two glasses from the cart at his side, then a carafe from which he poured water into both. He handed the glass as it was to Mr. Numbers, but dipped his finger into Mr. Transport's. Immediately the liquid bubbled and fizzed, stabilizing seconds later when Mr. Adair handed the glass to Mr. Transport.

Both drinks were delicious. Mr. Transport wished his had been made in the traditional way so he could have asked for a recipe.

"I know you boys are busy, so I won't mince words," said Mr. Adair. "You're here because you two are the admissions committee for the new program that is launching."

"Well, it isn't quite that simple," said Mr. Numbers. "There are evaluations and approvals and whatnot."

"Humility is wasted on the powerful, Mr. Numbers," said Mr. Adair. "You are two of the most trusted agents in your company, and with good reason. You both had abilities that could have made you well-known Heroes; instead, you chose to do the same work without the prestige. You are loyal, reliable, and dependable. Whomever you recommend for this program will be

who gets in. You know it, I know it, and everyone who matters knows it.” Mr. Adair punctuated his words by pouring himself a glass of water and swirling his finger about until the liquid turned a deep golden hue.

Mr. Numbers didn’t have a reply for this one. He could already see any attempts to defer responsibility on that account were a lost cause.

“So, with that said, I asked you here to meet me because there will be one addition to the program that you will both endorse fully,” said Mr. Adair, pausing to take a sip of his cocktail.

“And who would that be, sir?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“My daughter, Alice,” said Mr. Adair. “She is a Powered, a person born with super human abilities, but unlike a Super she lacks the capacity to freely control them. Though I’m sure your thorough friend here has already found that out.” Mr. Adair gestured to Mr. Transport.

“My research had said that she was in the non-lethal category,” said Mr. Transport. “She flies, correct?”

“You are correct, Mr. Transport,” said Mr. Adair. “My daughter’s power is tethered to her emotions, so when she gets happy she winds up bouncing off the ceiling. If we’re lucky enough to have a ceiling over her at the time.”

“Forgive me for saying this,” said Mr. Numbers. “But the program’s initial testing cases are supposed to be Powered with desirable abilities that are currently a danger to themselves and others.”

“I know,” said Mr. Adair. “That’s why I called you here to tell you that you would recommend her instead of going through the channels to submit her as a viable specimen.”

“With all due respect, Mr. Adair, that would compromise both our duties to the program and the company,” said Mr. Transport.

Mr. Adair said nothing in response at first. He leaned back in his own wicker chair and stirred his drink with his finger. As he stirred the colors changed, going through a rainbow of shades and depths. Finally it settled on a light pink and Mr. Adair took a sip.

“Mr. Transport,” Mr. Adair began. “You know what my code name is, correct?”

“The Alchemist,” Mr. Transport answered readily.

“Right, and you know why I am called that, yes?”

“Because you have the ability to manipulate and change the properties of matter,” said Mr. Transport.

“Correct again,” Mr. Adair said. “So maybe what you are missing is my role in this world. You see, while other Supers defend their homes or countries, I defend our economy. I turn radioactive sludge into oil, rocks into gold, worthlessness into pricelessness. Most Supers seek to garner favor from politicians and leaders. Leaders and politicians work to garner favor from me. I am one of the primary shareholders of the company you both work for, as well as several other powerful corporations. I am not going to threaten either of you, because we all know my abilities are ill-suited to a physical altercation. I am simply going to tell you that you will recommend my daughter for the first trial of the new program. End of story.”

Mr. Numbers looked at Mr. Transport. They had been partners for many years and had learned to read each other’s cues like a second language. There was no question for Mr. Transport as to what Mr. Numbers was telling him right then. Time to roll over.

“Yes, sir,” said Mr. Numbers.

“Good, I’m glad we understand each other,” said Mr. Adair. “So, when will things get started?”



# 1.

## Six Months Later

Vince adjusted his backpack to put the weight on his other shoulder. Two months since the procedure had ended and he'd been put in recovery and still his body felt like it was aching and healing. He never remembered feeling like this beforehand, but in fairness, there were plenty of other things that hadn't existed beforehand either.

Today was an excellent example of what going through the program had yielded him. He was walking across the beautiful, sprawling college campus of Lander University, passing other kids his age and blending in like a normal person. Well, almost anyway. His damn hair still made him stand out. One of his biggest hopes had been that a side effect of the procedures would be his hair becoming a normal color, but no such luck. It was still silver like it had always been. And not old man silver, either: silver like moonbeams glinting off steel. It wasn't that it was unattractive; in fact, it accentuated Vince's bright blue eyes quite nicely. No, the problem was that his hair marked him as different, and after all these years, Vince was yearning to be nothing more than a face in the crowd.

"At least we're in California," Vince mumbled under his breath as he quickened his steps. He was getting second glances from the other students, but not as many as he was used to. Aside from that, he passed a few people whose looks made him do double takes of his own. It was comforting, in a mutual freak sort of way. By the time Vince reached his dorm assignment, he was back on the positive side of things.

After all, this was what he had worked for during those two months of recovery, studying and being tutored so that he could get his GED and come to this college. It had been hell to concentrate, especially with his body still adjusting to everything, but he had put in the time and pulled it off. It was an opportunity he couldn't let slip away. Besides, the nurses and technicians had told him the other people from the program would be given the option to come here, too.

The building Vince walked up to looked less like a dorm and more like a medium-sized house. He didn't see how it was possible to fit many people in this one-story brick home, but he trusted that whoever was managing housing had that in hand.

Vince walked through the front door and shifted his backpack once

more. It bounced and landed on his shoulder lightly, betraying that it was far from stuffed to the brim with Vince's few articles of clothing and worldly possessions. One of the first things every wanderer lets go of is his unnecessary items. Travel light, move quick, stay alive. That was the code that kept Vince breathing and his abilities in check. But that was behind him.

In front of Vince was a cream-colored wall with a notice welcoming him to Melbrook Hall. There was another wall to his left and a hallway to his right. The notice had an arrow directing him to follow the foyer and then take a left. Vince did as he was told and found himself looking at a sturdy door with no window or discernible handle. There was only a small box jutting out with an oval-shaped green pad on top. Vince might not have been the most up-to-date with technology, but even he could figure this one out. He pressed his thumb to the oval, and after a minute the door opened with the sound of a small beep.

Vince stepped out of the foyer and into what looked to him more like a living room than anything else. There were several couches and chairs set up, a metal coffee table in the center of the room, and a large, flat-screen television on the wall directly across from him. It was decorated in white and red and smelled like an odd combination of flowers and chemicals, which Vince could only assume meant they were using an artificial air freshener. He walked around the room, taking in the scene.

On each wall perpendicular to the entrance was another metal door and scanner, these with signs above them. On the one to the left of the entrance was "Boys" while the one to right said, predictably, "Girls." Vince went over to the television, only to notice that there were open doorways on either side of this wall that one could walk through. Vince did just that and found himself in a white-tiled kitchen. It had a large sink, a stove with multiple burners and a griddle, and all kind of cooking knickknacks that Vince had neither the knowledge nor the experience to make anything out of.

At the back of the kitchen on the right was a cupboard, which Vince opened to discover a fully-stocked pantry. On the left was another metal door. This one, however, had neither a sign above it nor a fingerprint scanner.

Vince walked out of the kitchen and back into the living room, then over to the boys' door. As he walked, he carefully skirted away from wall outlets whenever possible. He hadn't had an accident since the procedure, but that didn't mean he was eager to test his luck. Pressing his thumb to the scanner, the door opened and Vince walked into what he could only assume was the common room.

There was another television on the far end, along with pool and Ping-Pong tables. The other end held a set of dart boards and a wooden door with the word “Bathroom” on it. Opposite of the entrance were three more metal doors. These had scanners clearly in place, but no signs, though they were numbered 1, 2, and 3. With a shrug and a heft of his pack, Vince walked over to the middle door. He pressed his thumb down and waited for the beep, but this time all that came out was a harsh buzzer. He tried twice more before giving up and trying the room on the left, which was room one. This time the door buzzed and opened, though Vince couldn’t help noticing a chime that followed the usual opening sounds. He wasn’t sure what that meant, and the sight before him left him little free brain space in which to contemplate it.

Saying his room was luxurious would be something of an overstatement, but it was definitely more opulent than a boy who was always on the run was accustomed to. There was a large bed in one corner with a desk and computer set up in the other. Between the two was a large window with sunlight streaming through the blue curtains. The floor was carpeted, and as Vince walked across it, he saw that opposite the desk there was a closet next to a chest of drawers. Slipping his pack off, Vince walked over and pulled open a drawer, trying to figure out if he had enough clothing to warrant any kind of organizational system.

He was shocked to see that the drawer he opened already contained many, many pairs of socks. Checking the next drawer, he found shorts, then T-shirts, then he went back to the top and found boxers. That drawer he slammed shut more quickly than the others. Synapses flying, Vince came to the only logical conclusion.

“Crud; this is someone else’s room.” It only made sense; this place was too nice and too well-furnished. Why had the door let him in, though? Vince brushed that thought out of his head quickly. It was faulty equipment, not his fault, but it wouldn’t make it less awkward if this room’s inhabitant came home to find an intruder. Vince turned on his heels, snatching up his backpack and bolting for the door.

All of which landed him face to face with a taller boy standing in the doorway, wearing sunglasses and running a comb through his sandy brown hair.

## 2.

Vince froze in place, staring at the room's owner and wondering how to explain the mix-up. It wasn't his fault after all, but this still wasn't the first impression he wanted to make on his new dorm mate. Vince groped around his head, looking for words to break the silence. Luckily, the boy in the door did it for him.

"Dude, that is some rocking hair," he said.

"Um, thank you," Vince replied softly. "I'm sorry I'm in your room. The door opened and I didn't know..." Vince just trailed off, the look of confusion on the boy's face making him more unsure with each passing second.

"You're not in my room, neighbor; you're in your room. I'm in two," the boy told him. "I heard you trying to buzz into mine and realized someone else was here, so I came to say hi."

"But this can't be my room," Vince said, trying to explain. "It already has sheets and clothes and everything."

"Yeah, my guess is that's because they thought you needed those things," the boy with sunglasses explained. "The doors are keyed to us; they only open for the right person. If this room opened for you, then it's because it's your room. Did you even read the letter they gave you?"

"Letter?" Vince asked with a sense of dread. He did remember a slip of paper that had fallen out of his pack when the taxi had dropped him off, but he had just dismissed it as an old food wrapper or something.

"I'll get mine," said the boy. "Hang on a sec... Um, what's your name?"

"Vince," said Vince.

"Nice. You can call me Nick," he said as he stepped out of the room. He came back mere moments later, holding a white piece of paper with fold lines across it.

"Here we go," Nick said. "Rooms have been set up for each attending member by the program. These will be stocked for members as deemed necessary, and are keyed to each attendee's individual fingerprints. Communal areas are open to all, but will be under the jurisdiction of your administrators. You are expected to be in the central common room promptly

at seven PM on move-in day to meet with your administrators and go over dorm rules’.”

“Huh,” said Vince. “Lucky you held onto that, or I wouldn’t have even known about the meeting, let alone about my room.” Vince plunked down on his bed, shedding his pack at long last.

“Good choice of words,” Nick commented, pulling out the chair from Vince’s desk and helping himself to a seat.

“What do you mean?” Vince asked.

“Eh, it’s nothing. Just... well, you said lucky,” Nick said.

“And... What about it?” Vince kept prodding.

Instead of answering, Nick pulled a set of dice from his jeans. He closed his eyes, an act only visible despite sunglasses due to the over-exaggerated scrunching of his face, and breathed deeply for a moment, then tossed them on to the desk.

“Double sixes,” Vince observed.

Nick nodded. He then took the dice, closed his eyes once more, and a deep breath later threw them on the table again.

“Double sixes. Again,” Vince said. “So you use trick dice?”

“Try them,” Nick replied. He scooped up the dice and offered them to Vince. Vince got off the bed, took the dice from Nick’s hand, and examined them. They had six different numbers on each side and felt as though they were weighted normally. Still, Vince wasn’t sure enough in his tactile perception to trust merely holding them for an answer. He threw the dice on the desk for himself.

“Three and five,” Vince said. “So you know how to spin them?”

“Do it again,” Nick told him. This time he closed his eyes and didn’t exhale until Vince’s throw hit the table.

“Double ones,” Vince noted. “So?”

“Again,” Nick instructed him.

Vince repeated his own throws three more times; each time, Nick closed his eyes and Vince wound up with double ones. After the third time, Vince let the dice rest on the table, then went back to his bed and sat on the edge.

“Are you telekinetic? Is that how you control the landing?” Vince asked.

Nick shook his head. “I can’t move things with my mind, at least not on purpose. My power is luck. It can be good or it can be bad, but if it’s luck then I’ve got some say over it.”

“Luck? How does that work? Not to insult, I just tend to think of luck as more of an abstract concept than a viable ability,” Vince said.

“No insult taken,” Nick assured him. “I don’t really know how it works. The docs tried to explain, something about quantum probabilities and minute alterations in the fabric of reality, but at the end of the day all I know how to say is that it’s luck. And mine is a lot better since I got it under control.”

Vince winced inwardly. “That must have been pretty terrible. Before.”

“It was and it wasn’t,” Nick said with a shrug. “At least my ability came in two flavors. You know I kissed a supermodel once? She was out with some friends and they played spin the bottle at the restaurant we were both at and, well... it pointed to me. Of course, then I went outside to find my car had caught fire, but hey, you got to take the good with the bad.”

“You’re upbeat about this,” Vince said.

“Sure I am,” Nick replied with a smile. “That’s all in the past. We’re not like that anymore. We’re the first people in history to go from being Powered to being Super. I still don’t understand what they did to us for those months and I don’t care. Far as I’m concerned, getting into that program was the best stroke of luck my ability ever gave me.”

“So, why the sunglasses?” Vince said to change the subject. He didn’t want to rain on Nick’s parade, but he’d been dealt too much disappointment in his life to just trust that his abilities were under control now and forever.

“If anyone in authority asks, it’s because using my power can give me headaches that leave me sensitive to light,” Nick explained. “But between you and me, I just think they make me look cool. What about your hair? Natural?”

“Unfortunately,” Vince replied. “One of those weird traits people with abilities sometimes get. The damn stuff basically drinks dye, too, so there’s no way for me to change its color.”

“You could shave it,” Nick pointed out.

“Thanks, but no thanks,” Vince countered. “I tried that once. Some

guys can pull off the bald look. I am not one of those guys. I'd rather be the weirdo with silver hair than the freakish man-baby."

"An understandable choice," Nick conceded. "Well, with you here that rounds out the boys' side. I wonder if any girls have gotten here yet."

"Wait, who's our third roommate?" Vince asked. "I haven't met anyone but you so far."

"Our third got here early and went out to explore campus," Nick told him. "You'll see him tonight at the dorm meeting. He's an... interesting fellow."

"That doesn't sounds good," Vince said.

"No, but it doesn't sound bad either," Nick pointed out. "Come on, you just arrived and I'm famished. Let's go hit up a dining hall for lunch."

"Do you know where one is?" Vince asked.

"Not really," Nick admitted. "But I bet we get lucky."

### 3.

Alice saw a pair of boys walking away from the building as she was heading towards it. They took no notice of her, clearly absorbed in their own conversation and playing catch with a pair of dice. Her new roommates, no doubt. Fantastic. At least the one with the brown hair was cute, or would be if it he weren't wearing those ridiculous sunglasses in the shade. The other one, though, who was he trying to impress with that hair? Silver and spiky, was he trying to flunk the secret identity challenge before the semester even started?

None of that was her concern, though. Daddy had been strangely unbending in denying her desire to dorm with the regular Supers, saying that she had to stay in the dorm set up for the "special cases" like herself. She didn't really see why she needed to be in the reinforced building; her ability was only flying, and she had suffered no uncontrolled attacks for over two months now. It was insufferable that she would have to... well, suffer through the group accommodations with a bunch of all-too-recently Powereds. Alice didn't want to find camaraderie in their shared former disability. She wanted to forget that part of her life had ever existed.

Still, no one could say that Alice Adair didn't make the best of a bad situation. She had taken a guiding hand in the construction of their dormitory, creating an environment that was spacious, desirable, and above all else, elite.

She breezed through the hallway, disregarding the note that hung on the entrance. A quick thumb scan took her to the central common room. She surveyed the work of the decorators critically. Yes, it would do nicely. Now at least when the other students asked her why she was in this small dorm set off at the edge of campus she could humbly explain that it was only available to those of sufficient means to afford such luxury and privacy. It wasn't her ideal situation, but it would work.

Alice moved briskly to the girls' side, anxious to get through lest the last boy be lounging about, hoping to sneak a peek at what members of the fairer sex would be sharing his roof space. The girls' side was identical to the boys', save that there were only two rooms, numbered 4 and 5 respectively. While group bathrooms were fine for males, Alice had been quite insistent with Daddy that she have her own private bathroom. The fact that this meant her fellow female received one as well was a very distant afterthought.

On that thought, Alice realized her other roommate was sitting in one of the plush pink chairs Alice had picked out, watching the television on mute. It seemed to be a game show, and the girl was as silent as the screen,



just watching and occasionally cocking her head to a different angle.

The girl was... wild seemed to be the word that popped into Alice's head first. Not wild in the sense of tequila, poor decisions, and eventual therapy, but wild in the way of the jungle. Her hair looked as though no one had even entertained the idea of touching it for years, sticking up at all angles willy-nilly. The girl's clothing was clean at least, though it had the look of something that had been worn for many years. Ironically, Alice's jeans had the same appearance, though hers had achieved the look through corporate innovation and the fashion demands of the public. The most disconcerting thing about the girl, though, was her eyes. While Alice had always considered her own green eyes, especially when paired with her platinum blonde hair, to be rather stunning, they held no candle to the amber irises that encircled this girl's pupils.

"Ahem," Alice said in her best impersonation of a throat clearing. "Good afternoon, I take it that you are my dorm mate?"

The girl swiveled her head toward Alice in a motion that seemed more owl- or hawk-like than human. She blinked those round amber eyes twice, then gave an oddly-shaped grin.

"You snuck up on me," that girl said.

"Oh, well, I do apologize," Alice said formally. Just because this girl seemed so uncouth didn't mean Alice could allow her own standards to lapse.

"Don't," said the girl. "I just keep forgetting people can do that now. It's a pleasant surprise every time."

"All right, then," Alice said, shifting on her feet uncomfortably. She knew everyone staying here had an ability, but she had been unable to wheedle Daddy into telling her precisely what to expect. "My name is Alice. What do you go by?"

The girl blinked oddly once more, then cocked her head before answering. "I haven't had any need to go by anything in a long time. My given name is Mary, though it might take a few tries to get my attention with it. As I said, out of practice."

"I think Mary is a lovely name," Alice said politely. In truth, she didn't care one way or the other, but as she couldn't very well go around all year referring to the girl as Freak Eyes, at least not out loud, Mary worked fine for her.

"I'll do my best to remember its mine," said the girl who was

apparently Mary, turning her head back to the television and watching her show.

“Um, if you don’t mind me asking, why are you watching it on mute?” Alice inquired.

“I used to always watch television like this,” Mary replied without turning around. “I learned to read their lips; that way, if I wanted silence, all I had to do was shut my eyes. It was the only thing in my life on which I could actually turn the voices off, so I relished it. I guess old habits die hard.”

“Ah, well, I see,” Alice said quickly, eyeing room number four and edging her way towards it. “Well, I’ll leave you to that, then. See you tonight at the meeting.”

With those words, Alice jammed her thumb on her door scanner and popped it open. She slammed the door immediately after and rested against her wall. It was strange how uncomfortable that girl made her, how it felt like, despite being so disconnected, Mary was looking right through her with those bright amber eyes. Alice had grown up wealthy and aristocratic, and if there was one thing she could not stand, it was the sensation that someone knew what she was really thinking.

Outside Alice’s door, Mary sat in the chair, eyes still trained on her game show. “That girl is more perceptive than she thinks,” Mary whispered to a small stuffed bear that sat between her leg and the armrest of the chair.

## 4.

“See, I told you we’d get lucky,” Nick gloated as he munched on a thick hamburger.

“We didn’t get lucky,” Vince corrected. “We got lost. For half an hour. Until I went into a building and asked for directions.”

“And wasn’t it lucky I brought along a guy with no masculinity issues about asking for directions?” Nick pointed out.

“I think you’re stretching on this one,” Vince replied, picking at the basket of chicken fingers. Being a wanderer had given Vince a pretty ironclad stomach when it came to grease and taste, but he had also always had to subsist on whatever was available at the time. As a result, he had a small appetite and an equally small percentage of body fat. He reflected ruefully that if only he had some muscle on his wiry frame it would have been very pronounced.

“I might be,” Nick admitted. “But then again, you haven’t even told me what you can do; who knows if you’re fit to judge the skills of others?”

“Shh,” Vince hushed him quickly. “We’re in public; you know we can’t talk about that kind of stuff.”

“Oh please,” Nick said, taking another bite of his burger then guzzling down soda. “We’re at one of the only five colleges in the nation that offer certification for Supers to become the government-approved responders known as Heroes. I’m sure, like, everyone in this cafeteria is a damn Super in disguise.”

The young men paused for a moment and looked around. Besides themselves, there was a small group of ladies halfway across the dining hall, and a large table mixed up of boys and girls clear on the other end. There were also a few tables where, like Vince and Nick, only one or two occupants sat. No one in the room looked particularly Super, or even interesting for that matter. Well, with the exception of the girl with short pink and black hair sitting with her friend. Vince did notice her as he did his visual sweep. Even aside from the colored hair, something about her stood out.

“Okay, maybe half the people,” Nick conceded as he finished looking around him.

“According to the doctors at who told me about this place, less than half of one percent of the student population is enrolled in the Hero

Certification Program,” Vince informed him. “So odds are pretty good you and I are the only people with abilities here.”

Nick let out a low whistle. “Less than half of one percent? That seems really low.”

Vincent shrugged. “There are a lot more humans than Supers. Even if this is only one of five schools, Lander is still a big university. A lot of people are going to come here wanting a run-of-the-mill education.”

“Poor bastards,” Nick said, shaking his head. “All kinds of awesome stuff going on around them and they have no clue about it.”

“At least they better not,” Vince said. “I heard that keeping your abilities a secret is, like, half of your grade. They say if you’re found out you have to do some kind of awful makeup courses to graduate, and that’s only an option if you’re at the top of the class.” Vince unthinkingly ran his hands through his hair. At least the campus was full of enough people with their own strange features that he might have at least half a chance of blending in.

“Don’t worry about the ‘do,” Nick told him. “I didn’t think it meant anything significant, and I already knew you had some sort of power when we met. Of course, I still don’t know what the damn thing is... But hey, that’s what friendships are built around, right? Secrets and mysteries.”

“You’re something of a drama queen, aren’t you?” Vince asked.

“Gasp! A dagger, straight into my heart,” Nick said, grasping his chest and leaning back in his chair. His breathing became labored and his hands slumped to the sides. He was dead, his life ended before its prime by the harsh words of someone he had thought of as a fast-growing friend. But hark! One of his hands lifted oh so slowly, making its way to the table and grappling the hamburger, then raising it triumphantly to his opened and waiting mouth.

“I don’t even want to know what’s going on in your head right now,” Vince said to his slumped-back friend.

“Good call,” Nick assured him.

Vince sighed and pushed away his now-forgotten chicken strips. Nick was loud, indiscreet as could be, and showy every chance he got. But he was also the only person to try to be Vince’s friend in years, and he knew what it had been like for Vince before. Those two qualities alone made him someone Vince knew he’d need to keep around.

“Get a book of matches and meet me back at the dorm,” Vince told

Nick. His words seemed to bring some life back into Nick's hamburger-munching corpse.

"You're supposed to wait until midterms before you go all pyro on shit," Nick chided him.

"I'm not going pyro! I just... Look: you said you wanted to know what I can do, right?" Vince asked him.

"Why yes, yes I do," Nick said with a series of enthusiastic nods.

"Then get a book of matches and meet me in the dorm," Vince repeated, pulling up the remainder of his food and walking away from the table. He dumped his refuse in the bin then made his way to the exit. He was relatively certain it would take Nick at least a few minutes to find some matches, plus a few extra to finish his burger. Vince was counting on those precious extra moments, because if he was going to try and do something with his power then he needed to get prepared and focus.

And, just to be on the safe side, pray.

## 5.

Vince had been in his room for only a few minutes when he heard a knocking at the door.

“No way he’s that fast,” Vince muttered to himself as he hopped up from his bed and opened the door. As it turned out, yes, there was a way that Nick was that fast.

“Hey, I grot mamfes,” Nick mumbled through a mouthful of burger. In all of the scenarios that had run through Vince’s head of how Nick would finish his meal and get matches, the possibility of Nick’s curiosity overwhelming his desire to eat while stationary was one that had not occurred.

“How did you find matches so quickly?” Vince asked as he gestured for Nick to sit in the computer chair again. Mercifully, this time Nick swallowed the food in his mouth before answering.

“They were lying on the ground by the door when I left the dining hall,” Nick explained.

“Let me guess: you used your power?” Vince asked rhetorically.

“Sure did,” Nick replied with a grin. “I wanted to get this show on the road.”

“Fantastic,” Vince said dejectedly. “Just what I needed.”

“Okay, see, now I’m confused. You’re the one who volunteered to show me what you can do. What’s the problem?” Nick asked.

“It’s... I guess it’s nothing, really. I just get nervous about using my ability,” Vince admitted.

“Still? Didn’t you go through the two months of therapy to get used to controlling it?” Nick took another bite of burger after his question, clearly banking on Vince to do some explaining.

“Yes, and I can control it... mostly. It’s just there are some aspects to it I’m still working on. Look, it should be fine. If we use matches then everything will be okay,” Vince said reassuringly, though he never could have admitted who he actually was trying to assure.

“Sweet,” Nick said as he polished off his lunch. “So what do I do?”

“Just face me and light a match, then hold it up in front of you,” Vince said. He sat down on the edge of the bed so that he was only a few feet from Nick.

“Can do,” Nick said, pulling a book of matches from his pocket and carefully extracting one from the end. Vince noticed the matchbook had a few missing from it already. It was a pretty decent guess that Nick had focused his luck and some poor smoker had dropped their matches without noticing. Much as he was hesitant to view luck as an ability, Vince had to admit it definitely had its uses.

Meanwhile, Nick had plucked his match and was trying to light it with all the skill of a drunken hobo. On his fourth try he finally got the match head to ignite and was so surprised he nearly dropped the small flame onto Vince’s carpet. He was able to keep his hold, though, and slowly moved the burning match so it was directly between himself and Vince.

Vince’s eyes were locked on the flame, focusing on it with all of his concentration. Ever so gently Vince raised his hand and opened it so that his palm was on level with the match. For a few seconds nothing happened, then the flame began to lean toward Vince’s palm. A moment later there was a small burst of heat and Nick was pinching only a tiny piece of ash between his fingers.

“Whoa,” Nick exclaimed. “What did you do?”

“I absorbed the energy of the flame,” Vince explained. “That’s my ability: I can absorb energy and store it for later.”

“What do you mean ‘for later’?” Nick said, already pulling out another match from the book.

In response Vince held up the index finger on his right hand. A small flame appeared at the tip of his finger, a flame about the same size and intensity as the he Vince had just vanquished. It burned for almost ten seconds, then vanished just as quickly as it had appeared.

“I can use the energy I absorb any time I want,” Vince continued once his finger was out. “I can use it slowly, like I did just now, or release it in controlled bursts. In this case it would have made a tiny fireball. I don’t have the ability to extend or increase it, though. However much energy I have absorbed at the moment is what I have to work with.”

“Awesome,” Nick said, nodding his head. “Now do this one.”

Vince sighed, but he couldn’t deny this was good practice anyway, so

he accommodated his dorm mate's demands for entertainment and absorbed the rest of the matches one by one.

"I have another question for you," Nick said as Vince snuffed out the final match from the book.

"Shoot," Vince replied. His mind had wandered off near the end of their practice session, focusing instead on how the aching weariness he had been fending off seemed to be decreasing a bit in his absorbing hand. He wondered if using a part of his body as an absorption point had pain-fighting properties.

"I get that you absorb the flame as it exists, but why is it every time you use your power, I wind up holding nothing but a fleck of ash? Does stealing the energy destroy the matchstick?" Nick was poking at the small piece of ash Vince's last absorption had left on his fingernail.

"Yes and no," Vince said, turning his attention back to his dorm mate. "Remember when I said I was still getting the hang of some stuff? Well, that's what I meant. See, I don't just absorb the existing energy: I absorb the potential energy as well. At least, I do if I don't sever the connection."

"Yeah, I've really got no idea what you're talking about," Nick said, flicking off the piece of ash and checking the matchbook to see if he had missed any.

"Okay... How to explain this? Look, let's pretend that you have another match and you light it, okay?" Vince said.

"Sure, why not," Nick agreed.

"Now, if you leave the match be, the fire will eventually consume all of the wood," Vince said. "However, if you were to lick your fingers and put it out halfway through then you would still have some of the matchstick left. With me so far?"

"Mostly," Nick said.

"Good," Vince said, choosing to plow ahead and hope for the best. "Well, obviously the match that is allowed to burn all the way down produces more fire, and therefore more energy. See, that's why the match disintegrates in your hand. When I steal the energy of the flame, I don't just take all the energy that's there, I also take all of the energy that has the potential to be there."

"I don't suppose you could break that down a little easier, could you?"



Nick asked, pulling out his dice and fiddling with them. Vince took a deep breath and tried to hold his patience. This could be a confusing concept if someone wasn't used to it; Vince needed to keep that in the front of his mind.

"Think of like this," Vince tried again. "There is only ash in your hand because in the fraction of a second that I begin drawing the energy of the match, the whole thing burns up in a flash and is taken into my body. That make sense?"

"Actually, yeah," Nick said. "But if it burns all at once then why aren't my fingers singed? I mean, if I'm holding it and it burns, it should hurt."

"You're not totally wrong," Vince said. "Normally that would still burn you. But heat is a form of energy, and I'm taking everything the match has to give. So, while it might flash burn in your fingers, all of the heat flows into me."

"Dude," Nick said. "I get it, but your power is fucking complicated."

"This from the guy whose ability works on quantum probabilities," Vince pointed out.

"I don't know what you're talking about," Nick said. "I just control luck. Nothing complicated about that."

"Right," Vince said sarcastically. "Nothing complicated at all."

## 6.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport sat at a small café in Paris, sipping their respective coffees. They had been saddled with a busy day so far; however, they were provided with a nice gap at lunch time, so Mr. Transport had suggested they adjourn to one of their favorite dining establishments. Mr. Numbers had concurred, and they had left the sweltering plains of Africa for a more tranquil and enjoyable environment in which to dine.

As was their custom, they were reviewing the particulars of their next assignment before departing. Mr. Transport had been somewhat surprised to see that their next job was classified as “long-term.” Those assignments were quite rare, given his and Mr. Numbers’ capabilities to handle things in a prompt and efficient manner. The deeper he read into the dossier, though, the more concerned Mr. Transport grew.

“Mr. Numbers,” Mr. Transport ventured tentatively.

“Yes, Mr. Transport?” Mr. Numbers replied without looking up from his own copy of the assignment file.

“Do you feel there perhaps there was a misfile and we were given someone else’s assignment?” Mr. Transport asked, trying desperately to keep any hope out of his voice. It was very bad for one’s job and health to be heard questioning the wisdom of the company they worked for.

“The possibility crossed my mind,” Mr. Numbers admitted. “However, if you read on, you will see certain accommodations at the place of employment have been made specifically for us. It even references us by name several times.”

Mr. Transport flipped a few pages ahead, and sure enough, Mr. Numbers had been correct. “Very well,” Mr. Transport said carefully. “Just wanted to be certain we were deployed to the right area.”

“Quite understandable,” Mr. Numbers agreed. “It would be irresponsible of us as agents to allow time and resources to be wasted on a clerical error. Since that is not the case, though, it seems we have a few more hours until we begin our new assignment.”

“That it does. Perhaps we should use that time to pack and prepare so we are properly equipped for the full term of the assignment,” Mr. Transport suggested.

“Excellent idea,” said Mr. Numbers. “Would you mind depositing me

first, then swinging back by in an hour or so to pick me up?”

“Not at all,” assured Mr. Transport. He reached into his wallet and pulled out a few bills. Mr. Transport kept a variety of currency for almost every country in the world available at his apartment. It was much faster than trying to haggle or work out an exchange rate every time, plus it allowed him and his partner to stay in the background, the area in which they were most comfortable. Mr. Transport set the money on the table, careful to tip generously. A moment later he and Mr. Numbers were gone.

Across the café, an elderly gentleman glanced at their table and noticed their absence. He nonchalantly folded his paper, set some money on his own table, and headed off to make a phone call. The elderly gentleman did not tip nearly as well as Mr. Transport.

\* \* \*

Several thousand miles away, in the middle of the Arctic tundra, Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers reappeared. Both began shivering almost immediately.

“How long?” Mr. Transport asked, willing his teeth to keep from chattering.

“Three minutes fourteen seconds until health problems begin to set in,” Mr. Numbers replied automatically as he felt the temperature around him, tested the speed of the wind, and added in the meager protection his black suit offered him.

“Watch is set for three minutes,” Mr. Transport said, quickly fiddling with the high-priced device on his wrist. Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport were very careful when they wanted to talk openly. They always selected areas with no possible people to surround them, in abstract locales and with ample background noise so that listening devices and GPS would be rendered ineffective. They never used the same place twice and always kept their conversations under five minutes. Say what you will about Mr. Numbers, he was a very calculating man. No pun intended.

“Now then, what do you actually make of our new assignment? Are we being punished?”

“For what?” Mr. Numbers shot back. “Our success percentage is 98 percent, we finish our missions in the fastest time of any team, and we have had no recorded insubordination in the history of our career.”

“Then what would make them do this to us?” Mr. Transport asked,

allowing the uncertainty and fear he had kept hidden away since he saw the document flood into his voice.

“We mustn’t assume the worse,” said Mr. Numbers. “Many of the reasons they had for putting us on this job are actually quite sound. They expect me to see any problems coming before they reach a critical point, and you’ll be necessary in the event we need to evacuate ourselves and any others involved.”

“I don’t imagine that’s really all there is to it,” Mr. Transport said flatly.

“Nor do I,” said Mr. Numbers. “Unfortunately, with the data I have, I don’t yet know what the ulterior motive of placing us in this position is. The only option we have is the same we’ve always had: do our jobs, stick to the books, and give me enough time to see what’s happening behind the scenes.”

“Do you think you’ll be able to figure it out before we’re stuck in whatever trap someone is planning?” Mr. Transport asked.

“I always have. Of course, that doesn’t mean I always will, but I don’t really see any other options available to us, let alone any better ones,” said Mr. Numbers.

“Agreed,” said Mr. Transport. A loud beeping began emanating from his wrist. Mr. Transport raised his watch and promptly turned it off. Without another word said, he and Mr. Numbers were gone from the sprawling white mounds of snow.

They reappeared in the apartment Mr. Numbers was currently renting under the name Mr. Digit. Mr. Transport tipped his head to Mr. Numbers then vanished to go pack his own bags. Mr. Numbers moved about his home, carefully controlling his movements so as not to show his body’s relief at entering in the heat, nor to shiver out of the residual cold still clinging to him. Instead he packed up his clothes, which consisted predominantly of suits, gathered his very few personal effects, then bagged up the remainder of his possessions, which were his toiletries. The room would need to be cleaned of all traces of him, but the company had a department for that. They would also take care of settling up the rent and making sure no one asked questions about Mr. Digit’s sudden departure.

Mr. Numbers took a moment to go to his window and pull back the thick black curtain. Looking out, he sighed as his eyes took in the splendor of Rome. From his vantage point he had an excellent view of the Coliseum. That was why he had chosen this apartment in the first place. Mr. Numbers was not

the type to get caught up in sentimentality or nostalgia, but as he sat on his window sill looking out, he had to admit that he was going to miss this view. He wished he could rent this place again once his assignment was over; however, that was against protocol. Once an agent had left a place he could never return.

Mr. Transport reappeared some time later, carrying a large, brown tweed suitcase and a black duffel bag. As Mr. Transport walked toward the window, Mr. Numbers noticed a slight clinking sound coming from Mr. Transport's bag. Mr. Numbers bit back his desire to chastise Mr. Transport for bringing along alcohol. Given what the duo would soon be doing, there was a very strong possibility that Mr. Numbers would be seeking a nip of the hard stuff himself.

"Ready?" Mr. Transport asked as he reached the window and joined Mr. Numbers.

"Of course," Mr. Numbers replied on cue, holding his own baggage firmly so it wouldn't be left behind.

Then the room was empty, only the slight echo of a voice filled with duty and the warm Roman sunlight left to fill it.

## 7.

The silver-haired boy was fidgeting nervously. Alice noted that in the back of her mind, not particularly intrigued but not ambivalent either. Every little detail added up to the sum of who a person was, and that was information worth having if she was going to be dealing with these people on a regular basis.

The five students were assembled in the central common room scattered among various seats. Mary was off to the side on her own, save for the stuffed bear she kept perched carefully in her lap. Alice had been tempted to ask why Mary had a stuffed animal, but the moment she had looked into those amber eyes all desire had melted away in the face of the overwhelming certainty that talking to Mary was a bad idea.

The boys were clustered together for the most part. Silver hair and sunglasses were lounging on the white couch, with the third boy in the chair to their side. He was a husky one, wearing a shirt that had strangely shaped dice on the front. Alice deduced within a few moments of hearing him speak that the boy was certainly lacking the basic set of social skills. Then again, given who she was surrounded by, she could hardly say that he didn't fit in.

Alice herself had taken a center position in the room, eager to appear eager for whatever authority figure Daddy had managed to wrangle into this baby-sitting job. Alice didn't expect for whoever showed up to pose any real problem for her; after all, they would obviously know who her father was, but she still preferred to get her way through charm and cunning rather than threats and force. It was the way a proper lady got things done.

As the clock struck seven, a bit too loudly, Alice noted with a grimace, a pair of men appeared in front of the group of students. They dressed almost the same, save that the shorter of the two wore a tie while the taller one did not. They wore black suits and white shirts, both kept their dark hair trimmed and while the short one had bright blue eyes, the larger one had only muddy brown ones.

"Hello, students," said the shorter of the pair. "You may call me Mr. Numbers. My friend, Mr. Transport, and I are here to oversee and assist you in your academic endeavors. Our apartment is what lies behind the steel door in the kitchen. You will not be permitted access; however, an intercom is on the counter next to the pantry for emergency contact. Do we have any questions so far?"

Alice glanced around to test the temperature of the room. It seemed everyone but she and Mary were struck dumb by the appearance and promptness of the two men who had materialized in front of them. Alice suppressed the urge to scoff. Of course these poor dregs were surprised; their only experience with people who had abilities was undoubtedly with others like themselves. The sight of someone using precision teleportation would be truly alien to them. Alice wasn't quite sure why Mary wasn't more taken back, but she readily chalked that up to just another aspect of the girl's strangeness.

"I take your silence to mean we are on the same page," Mr. Numbers continued. "Now, I want to be clear here. We've met most of you already when we were selecting people appropriate for the program you all participated in. We were nice and friendly then. We will continue to maintain that same level of friendliness during our tenure as your house administrators. However, please do not misinterpret my good nature as weakness. Mr. Transport and I are here to enforce the rules, and you will find we are both excellent at our jobs."

"Um, what rules are you talking about?" The question came timidly from the silver-haired boy.

"A full copy will be issued before the week is over," Mr. Numbers replied. "I will touch briefly on the main three, though. First, you are to keep your identities secret at all times. This is a requirement of all those who participate in the Hero Certification Program, or HCP as we call it around here, and it is the duty of the administrators to observe who has broken it, intentionally or otherwise. That will be covered in more depth tomorrow during your first class. Secondly, there is to be no fighting with other Supers or with regular humans outside the confines of the classroom."

"Wait," the silver-haired boy said again. "We're going to fight in class?"

"Of course," said Mr. Numbers. "You are training to be a Hero. This means you must learn to fight against time, villains, and environmental conditions to save as many people as possible in any given scenario. Combat training will be a very important part of that."

"Don't worry," Mr. Transport broke in, speaking for the first time. "All fights are strictly monitored, and there is always someone with a healing power on hand to tend to both parties afterward."

"Mr. Transport is correct, though both he and you could stand to take a course in not interrupting," Mr. Numbers said, staring at the silver-haired boy.

“Now then, the third rule is the most important for all of you. Your powers must stay within your control at all times. This is a rule specific to your situation and certainly doesn’t need explanation. Be aware that this is the primary reason Mr. Transport and myself were selected for this assignment. Should any of you lose control, we will act quickly and decisively to ensure the safety of those around while simultaneously shutting down the problematic party.”

“Wait; I thought we all had control of our abilities. That’s why they let us enroll here.” This time the speaker was the dark-haired boy wearing sunglasses. Alice noticed he spoke with a strange accent. Not quite northern, but not quite southern, either. It seemed to be a hint of dialect from a region all its own.

“You all do have control of your abilities. Currently,” said Mr. Numbers. “The procedure you underwent was experimental, though. Those who created and performed it are certain you will remain as Supers and not drift back to your previous uncontrollable states. However, there are those who remain skeptical such a thing is possible, and the positioning of Mr. Transport and me as overseers is a compromise to assure the safety of the regular student body.”

“So what happens if someone loses control?” Alice was shocked to realize this question had come from her own mouth. It wasn’t as if she was a danger to anyone if she began floating around again, but she was concerned that the slip-ups of some of these cretins could affect her college career. At least, that’s how she rationalized the sudden nagging fear that had formed in her stomach.

“Testing,” Mr. Numbers replied simply.

“What Mr. Numbers means to say,” Mr. Transport said, jumping in as he saw the looks of distress cross his charges’ faces, “is that we will test and investigate the reason why control was lost. Maybe there was a psychological component and it doesn’t mean things failed. Maybe it’s an individual case, or maybe it just means that person will need another round of treatment. We don’t anticipate anything going wrong with any of you, but if it does then we’ll be there to find out exactly why it happened.”

“I feel testing was an adequate answer,” Mr. Numbers said. “Now, do any of you have any questions about the rules I have set down so far?”

There was silence, though this time it was less motivated by being dumbstruck at the dramatic entrance and more motivated by the sudden fear they had all presumably acquired of someone losing control and screwing the



deal for everyone.

“Excellent,” Mr. Numbers said. “Then I will turn the floor over to Mr. Transport for some ‘getting to know our dorm mates’ activities.” With that, Mr. Numbers sat down in the chair directly opposite of Alice. Alice, for her part, worked very hard to avoid his observant blue eyes and focus on the tall Mr. Transport. It seemed that everyone was following her lead on that account; everyone, that is, except for Mary.

Mary was staring directly into Mr. Numbers’ big blue eyes, meeting his gaze with her own amber orbs. Since everyone was gazing intently at Mr. Transport, no one noticed the two looking at each other. If they did, though, certainly no one noticed as Mary brought both of her hands up and began clapping them together softly, engaging in a very gentle, very silent, session of applause.

## 8.

“Well then,” Mr. Transport said as the eyes of his charges fell curiously upon him. He was glad Mr. Numbers had allowed him to be the “good cop” in their interaction with the students, but he still felt a bit awkward dealing with a group of eighteen-year-olds. After all, Mr. Transport could scarcely remember a time when he shared the worries and concerns of an everyday teen. Of course, the reason Mr. Transport had trouble finding those memories is because they didn’t exist. Being able to pop out of nearly every situation had a profound impact on diminishing the amount of things he had to worry about in his formative years. “Why don’t we do an exercise to get to know one another better?”

Mr. Transport waited for some sign of agreement or excitement from the students. Instead he got back blank stares, so after a moment he elected to take that as the sign of their agreement. “Okay,” Mr. Transport continued. “Here is how it works. I want everyone to stand up, say their full name, what their ability is, where they are from, what their cover major is, and one interesting fact about themselves.”

Again Mr. Transport was met with silence; having settled on choosing to perceive that in the positive, though, Mr. Transport was able to keep right on trucking. “I’ll begin. My name is Mr. Transport. My power is teleportation of myself and others. My birth location is considered classified. I am not currently enrolled in Lander University, so I lack a major, and my interesting fact is that I collect bottle caps from sodas all over the world.”

“They still make soda in bottles?” Nick asked skeptically.

“Yes, they do, in other countries as well as in America,” Mr. Transport answered, gratefully to have anyone say anything. “Why don’t you pick up the ball and tell us about yourself now?” Mr. Transport had something that almost seemed like conversation momentum and he would be damned if he was going to lose it.

“No prob,” said Nick, standing from the couch. “Nick Campbell, and I’ve got the power of creating and controlling luck. I’m from Sin City itself, good old Vegas. I’m majoring in business while at Lander. My interesting fact is that I’ve been punched in the mouth by a senator.” With that, Nick plopped back down in the sofa and threw on a big, broad smile.

“Punched by a senator? Would you care to elaborate on that story, Mr. Campbell?” Mr. Transport asked.

“You’re not the only one with shit that’s classified,” Nick answered.

“Okay then,” Mr. Transport said quickly. “Who would like to go next?”

Before the word “next” was fully out of his mouth the blonde girl sitting directly opposite him and Mr. Numbers had popped up from her chair like there was a spring loaded in it. He hadn’t yet had the pleasure of meeting this young lady, but by process of elimination he knew who she was before she began to speak.

“My name is Alice Adair, and I have the power of flight. I’m from Los Angeles, California. While at Lander I will be enrolled in the communications program. An interesting fact about me is that I have been riding horses since I was five and have won several championships,” Alice said with a firm tone and a confident aura. She was a bit agitated that the sunglasses boy, or Nick as it were, had beaten her to being the first to speak, but she kept that annoyance off of her face as she returned to her seat and smiled placidly.

“Very nice to meet you, Alice,” said Mr. Transport. “Who wants to go next?” He braced, waiting for another student to pop up, but it became all too apparent he had already worked his way through the confident public speakers in his group. Well, no matter; Mr. Transport knew the default solution for problems like this.

“Well, since no one wants to volunteer anymore, how about we just start at this end of the room,” he said, pointing to Hershel, “and we’ll work our way down.”

There were some mumbling and dissatisfied tones, but slowly Hershel rose to his feet. The boy looked a bit better than when Mr. Transport had last seen him. The months of therapy and procedures had shrunk him from round to a wide husky, though the confidence of an elf lord about to siege a castle was strangely gone from his eyes and body language. Now that Mr. Transport thought about it, Hershel and that small girl, Mary, were the only two who hadn’t spoken a word since he and Mr. Numbers appeared in the room.

“My name is Hershel Daniels, and I’m from Chicago. I’m majoring in creative writing, and an interesting fact about me... is... um... well, I won a couple of writing competitions for my fantasy short stories,” Hershel said in soft tones. He moved to sit down, but Nick stopped him.

“You forgot to tell us what your power is,” Nick pointed out.

“Oh,” Hershel said. “Um... well, I guess that’s because I don’t really

have any powers. I mean... I do, but... it's complicated."

"How complicated can it be?" Nick kept pressing. "You can either do something superhuman or you can't."

"Well, it's more that I do something, and then I can do something super. Does that make sense?" Hershel asked timidly.

"He's a shifter," Mary said from her chair on the end.

"Oh, why didn't you say so? So you turn into some other form that has the powers, right?" Nick asked.

"Yes," Hershel said, nodding emphatically. "That's how it works."

"No shame in that," Nick said reassuringly. "Some of the best Heroes on the record books had to go through a transformation before they were ready for business. It makes keeping your secret identity and Hero identity separate all the easier, too."

"I guess it does," Hershel agreed, looking thoughtful about the benefit Nick had brought up. He sat down in his chair successfully at last, the burden of speech passed off of him and on to the next poor sap.

Since the person to Hershel's right was Nick, who had already gone, the turn skipped to Vince. It wasn't really that Vince was scared to talk in public; it was just that everything in him was ingrained to go against the idea of volunteering. In his world, volunteering drew attention, and attention made people notice he was different. Once people noticed that, well... things always had a tendency to get far too interesting for Vince's tastes.

Vince rose to his feet and addressed the room. "My name is Vince Reynolds. My power is the absorption, storage, and redistribution of energy. I'm from New York... originally. I'm enrolled as undecided as far as my major goes. My interesting fact is that I've been in forty of our fifty states." Vince sat back down on the couch quietly.

"I have to ask, how do you get your hair that color?" Alice said once Vince had hit the couch. She didn't really care about who his stylist was, but she was curious. The strong tone and voice that had come from Vince didn't match up with the skittish body language she had seen all night. She wanted to hear more from him to try and reconcile that personality discrepancy.

"I don't," Vince said, this time a bit sheepishly. "My hair is naturally this color, and for some reason I can't get dye to stick in it."

"Oh," Alice said. "I'm sorry, I didn't know." That was unfortunate;

she had been planning on getting a full course of dialogue from him, but if it was natural and a feature he was clearly embarrassed about, then there was no way for her to press onward from her present position.

“Don’t worry about it,” Vince said quickly. “Nick more or less asked the same thing when he first met me. It’s good that people think I dye it this way, it makes it easier to blend in as a human.”

“Very positive attitude, Vince,” Mr. Transport said. “Now then, shall we hear from our last student?”

All eyes turned to the short, wiry girl who had thus far only spoken once, on Hershel’s behalf at that, in the course of the night. Unlike the others, Mary didn’t stand. She delivered her introduction from a cross legged sitting position in her chair.

“My name is Mary,” she began. “And my power is an advanced brain which gives me telekinesis and telepathy. I was born in Louisiana, but I’ve been in the forests of Colorado for about eight years now. I’m double majoring in psychology and biology, and an interesting fact about me is that I know how to turn beavers into hats.”

“What’s your last name?” Hershel asked.

Mary blinked several times then let her gaze move around the room. She unconsciously let her hands pet the head of the stuffed bear in the lap. A few seconds of silence passed, and Mary looked back at her fellow dorm mates.

“I don’t really remember. Like I told Alice, I haven’t had any need for names in a very long time.” Mary asked.

“Thankfully we had ample need,” Mr. Numbers interjected. “Your last name is Smith. You may check the releases your parents signed if you need confirmation.”

“I have no reason to doubt you,” Mary said graciously.

“Thank you, Mary,” Mr. Transport said. “Tell me, does your bear have a name?” He was fairly certain girls who were Mary’s age didn’t name their stuffed animals, but then his understanding was that eighteen-year-olds didn’t normally keep their stuffed animals with them out in the open anyway, so he opted to ask anyway in the hopes of seeming friendly.

“No,” Mary said bluntly.

“I see, that was a silly question,” Mr. Transport said hurriedly.

“Why do you think that?” Mary asked him.

“Well, because you’re obviously old enough that you wouldn’t be naming your bear,” Mr. Transport said.

“You misunderstand,” Mary told him. “I did name my bear. His name is No.”

“Huh,” said Mr. Transport. “Why did you name him No?”

“Why not name him No?” Mary responded.

“Yes, well.” Mr. Transport paused and resisted the urge to press his fingers to his temples. He didn’t need the children seeing that he could be annoyed, gotten to, or given a headache. It was best to just get things back to business. “Since Mr. Numbers already introduced himself, that takes care of the meeting agenda for tonight. One last thing before Mr. Numbers and I retire. As you were all told, classes for Lander take place on the ground level, while classes for the Hero Certification Program take place in a special underground campus. Now, other dorms that house Supers have special elevators to convey their students between campuses. However, since ours is new and it is not yet hooked up to the network, I will be your method of travel between these two schools.”

“Why couldn’t we just get clearance to use an elevator at a nearby dorm?” Nick asked.

“Too much paperwork,” Mr. Transport said with what he hoped was a believable grin. “No, in reality it is simply that getting approval takes months and months, and since we weren’t sure if any of you would be able to attend this year, we were unable to secure that approval in time. Fear not, though, for I know all of your class schedules and I will always be around to teleport you as needed.”

“How do we get back up?” Nick said, asking yet another question.

“You can call for me on my phone or you can ride the elevator. Getting up doesn’t require clearance; only going down. Now, I’m sure you all know there is a meeting welcoming you all tomorrow at eight in the morning, so I expect to see each of you here ready to go promptly at seven forty-five. Aside from that, please intermingle, get to know one another, and have a great night.”

Mr. Transport gently kicked Mr. Numbers, who said something that might or might not have resembled “good night”, depending on the language one was using as well as the level of sarcasm tolerated before the meaning of

a word was reversed.

With a nod and a smile, Mr. Transport vanished, presumably taking Mr. Numbers with him since the chair Mr. Numbers had occupied now sat empty. The students were overtaken with surprise at the disappearance once again, though this time the spectacle wore off much more quickly. The vanishing administrators did leave behind a vacuum in conversation, rendering the five gifted individuals with no idea what to say to one another. This vacuum was broken quickly by Nick, whose powers evidently included a need for attention and an utter lack of social insecurity.

“Okay,” Nick said. “I’m now officially taking bets. Gay couple or just a pair of best friends who secretly wish they were a gay couple?”

## 9.

The first thing Nick did, once he had secured his door tightly shut behind him, was to shed those idiotic sunglasses. He blinked several times as his eyes readjusted, then strolled over to his desk and turned on his computer. He opened a word processing program and immediately began writing down the day's events with as much detail as he could remember. It was a very minor challenge for him. There had been times before he had gained control of his power when he would go weeks between note-taking sessions, and he had still managed to glean information from those.

Nick made no motion to save his file as he typed. He had procured a surge protector that doubled as a battery in case of a power outage, so he was relatively certain nothing would interrupt his process or destroy his work thus far. It was probably redundant in a place like this with safeguards on top of the safeguards, but Nick hadn't survived eighteen years of bipolar luck without learning to be a little redundant in his safety measures.

It took him only a few minutes to finish - Nick had shockingly quick hands - and then he leaned back in his chair and began reviewing the day's events. He had done quite well and had adhered to the primary tenants of survival in a new area: speak much, say little, and see all. The glasses had been a good addition; he needed to thank Ms. Pips for that suggestion next time he was in Vegas. They kept anyone from reading what was on his face effectively, and they made him look like something of a jackass.

That suited Nick's needs just fine. People overlooked and underestimated those they thought of as stupid, which was precisely what he wanted. Nick was a boy who could affect the outcomes of dice throws in a school for people who could lift cars and eat fire. He was going to need every advantage he could get, and surprise was an excellent one to have.

Nick continued scrolling down, rereading his own recent notes. He had befriended Vince easily enough, and Hershel was socially ignorant, so getting on his good side had only required minor encouragement. Mary was a lost cause; Nick needed a telepath hanging around him like he needed a bullet to the head. Alice, on the other hand, was a whole different story. She had some skill in reading people, but her subtlety and manipulation skills were amateurish at best. The way her eyes had been darting about during the meeting, how she tilted her head when she was trying to figure out a new aspect to someone, the clumsy way she tried to lead a conversation with Vince, all of those had been tells of a novice. Nick estimated he could get her to trust him within the span of a month. After all, there were few things as



vulnerable as someone with just a little bit of knowledge.

The two agents he had babysitting him were going to be simple to get around. They had run a classic “good cop, bad cop” routine to categorize their interactions with the students. As long as he created some personal problems to ask Mr. Transport for help with and let Mr. Numbers yell at him occasionally for minor discipline issues, neither one would think to wonder what was going on behind those sunglasses.

Nick finished reading his notes, then went through them twice more. After the final pass, Nick deleted every word he had written and closed the file without saving, making sure to purge the autosave function as he did so. That done, he undressed and got into bed. He would plan for how to handle the next day for only an hour, then allow himself to get some sleep. He needed to be in top form when he met the other students, after all.

\* \* \*

Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers sat at the dining table in their new apartment. It was a spacious two-bedroom that existed behind the door in the kitchen. They would, of course, be sharing the cooking area with the children, but since the kids had meal plans and little practical experience in taking care of themselves, neither Mr. Transport nor Mr. Numbers anticipated battling with them for space on the stove.

They had also been provided with their own mini-fridge, which Mr. Numbers took as a negative sign indicating some higher up was aware of Mr. Transport’s penchant for beer and liquor. Still, the fridge was there, so Mr. Transport had put his beer and a bottle of gin in it as they unpacked. Now the two sat, still clad in their suits, going over their assignment folders one last time before the mandatory destruction of them.

“Do you think it went well?” Mr. Transport asked from his seat.

“Exceedingly,” Mr. Numbers said. “We made them perceive us in the way they were supposed to. The only exception, of course, is the telepath.”

“She shouldn’t pose a problem for us, though,” Mr. Transport said. “Remember your training. Telepaths can only read what is going through your mind at that moment. Just be careful and remember to control your thoughts around her.”

“I’m aware of the necessary techniques,” Mr. Numbers said with a slight edge to his voice. “I’m just not certain it holds true with that one. There’s something about her, something different. I worry she might be able to go deeper than most telepaths.”

“I’m sure the doctors or nurses would have made note of it in the file. Besides, why would a telepath who has spent her life without control of her ability be more adept with it than those who have honed it through a lifetime of practice?” Mr. Transport asked.

Mr. Numbers let out a small sigh. “I suppose you’re right. Still, we’ll have to stay on our toes around her. Heaven knows we have secrets we can’t afford to let some eighteen-year-old girl in on.”

“I thought she was seventeen,” said Mr. Transport.

“She was when we met her, but she had her birthday while she was undergoing treatment,” said Mr. Numbers.

“Oh. I do hope they did some sort of celebration for her,” said Mr. Transport.

“It is to my understanding that there was cake,” assured Mr. Numbers.

“Very good then,” said Mr. Transport. “Well, I’m ready when you are.”

“Let’s get the lighter and the bucket,” said Mr. Numbers.

\* \* \*

Alice tossed and turned sleeplessly in her bed. A telepath! What had her father been thinking, allowing a telepath to be her dorm mate? He knew how much she valued her privacy. At least, she had thought he knew. What was she going to do? That Mary girl could be listening to her at that very moment. She would never know a moment’s peace; never know a good sleep again.

Alice had always been excellent at reading others, a skill she had first learned from watching her Daddy interact with other people. Now she was stuck with a dorm mate who had been living in the damn forest for the last few years and who was a mind reader to boot. All of Mary’s social habits had been scrubbed clean by the wilderness and the solitude, so Alice had no idea what was going on in her head. On top of that, Mary could see Alice’s thoughts plain as day.

Never had the tables been turned on Alice like this, never had she felt so exposed, so vulnerable. Her only consolation was that the others would be simple to deal with. Hershel was a big, insecure geek, Nick was a tongue-wagging idiot, and Vince was uncomfortable with his own uniqueness. They had all shown weaknesses to capitalize on for her own gain, so she was

comfortable with them. As for the agents, Alice barely spared a thought for them. They worked for Daddy, because whether they knew it or not, everyone worked for Daddy in some way. She would be polite, and if they crossed her, she would handle them.

No, there was no problem with anyone else. Alice flipped over in her bed for the thousandth time, trying to figure out how to handle Mary.

\* \* \*

Hershel was also thinking about Mary, though he and Alice had very different problems with the girl.

“She was so pretty,” Hershel said to no one. He used to have friends, back before Roy had begun popping up more frequently, and had even managed to hang on to some personal connections through his LARP group. Those were gone now, back in Chicago, while he lay in bed alone. He desperately wished he still had them so he could tell them about his day, about how he had gotten Roy under control, and about the beautiful girl with the amber-colored eyes he had met on his first day at college.

Hershel could do none of those, though, so instead he was talking to an empty room. He wished he could have talked to her after the meeting was over, but she went back to the girls’ side almost as soon as the two administrators were gone. Did she know he was going to talk to her and that’s why she ran? A wave of insecurity washed over Hershel, one that he was more than accustomed to. Hershel was pudgy, shy, and unremarkable. He had spent his whole life feeling those waves of insecurity crash against him. The only times they weren’t there was when he was dressed up in costume pretending to be someone else. Then he was brave, strong, and confident. Then he was someone worth being.

Hershel felt something stir in his mind. He realized he had been calling out to Roy without noticing. That seemed to happen at his lowest points, when he wanted to be anyone else in the world besides Hershel Daniels. If not for the treatment, Roy would probably have appeared already. Fortunately, that was no longer the case. Hershel could call to him all night, but until he used the trigger that had been created, Roy would stay nothing more than a tickle in the back of his head.

Still, it was hard enough to get to sleep alone. Hershel didn’t want to try and pass out with both of them stirring, so he decided to think of something besides Mary and how insecure she made him feel.

“She really is so pretty,” Hershel said once more. He rolled over and

tried to visualize anything besides Mary's amber eyes.

\* \* \*

In her own room, Mary blushed.

"Yes, I think he's very sweet, No," she said to her bear. "I just think he needs a little more time to acclimate to college on his own. This is a big new environment, and if I were to be with him, I'd become nothing more than a security blanket."

The bear stared back at her from his resting place on the bed.

"Okay, you got me. I also want to see what his other side is like," Mary admitted. "Besides, there are much more interesting thoughts going on right now, don't you agree?"

No said nothing.

"So many people thinking of little old me," said Mary. "I feel like this is going to be a very interesting year."

No still said nothing.

"Oh, you rascal," Mary laughed. "Maybe after a few weeks. Right now we need to get to bed. It's going to be very loud tomorrow unless we're rested and in control."

Mary scooped up No and got under the covers with him. Like turning off a light switch, Mary banished away the voices from her head. Just like that it was as though she were back in the forest, communing with the quiet. The ability to have silence on demand, that was something she would never grow tired of.

\* \* \*

Vince was asleep. Unlike the others, he hadn't had any large revelations about his roommates or sudden fears about the day to grapple with. Vince had merely come in, undressed, and gotten into bed.

Of course, before he slept, Vince had tenderly removed a gold pocket watch from his backpack and gently wound it as he did every night. He then checked the time and made sure the watch was running right then set it down in a place of honor on his bedside table.

Then he had gotten into bed himself, pausing on his direct flight toward the land of slumber only long enough to run a finger along the watch and softly whisper, "Goodnight, Father."

After that, he was gone into a dream that seemed to feature fire more heavily than the ones he had regularly.

## 10.

“Welcome, freshmen!” The speaker was a tall man with glasses, black hair, and a charcoal-colored suit. He cut an impressive figure even from behind his podium, looking around the room emanating confidence and ease, as though he had made this speech dozens of times before. Which, coincidentally, he had.

“It is my pleasure as Dean of the Hero Certification Program to be the first to congratulate you on making the cut and being enrolled in our very elite little academy,” the dean continued. “My full name is Blaine Geffries, however, I want you all to just call me Dean Blaine. It is my hope that each and every one of you grow stronger in the years ahead, and that the best of you graduate from here with full certifications and go on to become acclaimed Heroes. I want to watch all of you find the lessons you need to succeed!”

“Of course he does,” Nick muttered to Vince quietly from his seat in the middle of the auditorium. “The more prestige a Hero has, the better it looks on the school that trained them.”

“I didn’t think the five universities that ran this program were in competition,” Vince said curiously.

“Where there is money, there is competition, and these bad boys are government-funded,” Nick replied.

“Now, I know all of you are a little nervous,” Dean Blaine said in an understanding voice. “After all, most of you are from schools, if not towns, where you were the only Super present. Having peers around you who can understand and relate to what you’re going through is a new experience, and I’m here to tell you that it will be a wonderful one. You’re going to have friendships, support, and respect all built on the mutual understanding that only fellow Supers can share.”

“Is being a Super hard?” Vince whispered to Nick. “I knew a few of them, and by comparison to... everyone else, it seemed like they had it pretty easy.” Vince chastised himself internally. He had just referenced himself as something other than a Super, a taboo Mr. Transport had advised them against committing before he brought them down that morning. It wasn’t just that the program that had created them was classified, which it was, the problem was that if the other students knew what Vince and his group had once been Poweredreds they were almost sure to face harassment and discrimination. Of

course, in a school where there were telepaths, any secret was inevitably going to come out. The goal was merely to avoid that day for as long as possible.

“It isn’t really hard, per se,” Nick responded, breezing over Vince’s near screw-up. “It’s just different. I know you were on your own most of the time, but for those of us around people it was an odd experience, always knowing you were the one who was different.” Nick was careful to try and cover for Vince, not out of friendship but out of necessity. Nick wanted every advantage he could get his hands on, and being targeted as a freak among freaks would rob him of too many opportunities for him to permit it.

“You’re going to need that support network, too,” Dean Blaine continued. “As all of you should know, becoming a Hero is a grueling task. You’ll be taking combat classes, training your tactical skills, learning to think around corners, and - possibly most importantly of all - you’ll be learning about the ethics behind having and using abilities. And, of course, you’ll be doing all of that while maintaining your secret identity up top.”

The sound of groans permeated the audience, which was about fifty people strong. Dean Blaine only gave this talk to freshmen, and despite what many conspiracy theorists believed, the portion of the population that were Supers was still remarkably small. Of course, the percentage jumped considerably if one were to include Powereds as well, but no one did.

“Now, now, none of that,” said Dean Blaine without breaking his smile. “I know many of you have lived out in the open about your abilities for years, but this is how we do things at Lander. Learning to protect a secret identity helps you hone a lot of the skills a Hero will need. Ingenuity, thinking on your feet, and planning are all major elements of keeping your secret safe. Those of you who fail at keeping your secret... well, let’s just say that fail was the operative word there.”

There was no laughter at Dean Blaine’s joke, not that he had expected any. That was a joke just for him.

“Of course, there are always extenuating circumstances, but let’s just say you should do your best to keep the fact that you’re a Super close to the vest. If you need to show off, work out, or just get the powers pumping, then you are always welcome down here, where you can be the Super we all know you are,” Dean Blaine reassured them.

“Lovely,” Alice said to no one in particular. She had opted to sit alone near the top of the tiered auditorium. She loved that sort of spot because it allowed her a vantage point above all the others, observing and noting their

behavior. She had also chosen it because Mary, and for some reason Hershel, had both sat near the bottom. Alice was not about to give that girl any more time staring into her mind than she had to.

“With that settled, let’s go over today’s activities, shall we?” Dean Blaine asked rhetorically. “Since above ground classes don’t start until tomorrow, we’ll be using today to do our combat ranking. For those of you who don’t know, we do rankings among the classes at the beginning of this and end of every other year. This is so we can get a sense of where you’re starting from based on the previous test, and how much you’ve grown by the end. We won’t just be taking into account who wins each fight; we’ll be looking at how they use their abilities, bodies, and brains to make the most of every situation. Today’s will be a single elimination tournament, so the more you win, the more you fight, the better a chance you have to showcase what you can do.”

Vince felt his heart sink. All he had for energy was the half a book of matches he had absorbed yesterday while showing off for Nick. Unless he fought someone with electrical or fire abilities, he was going to be working at a big disadvantage. It was really his own fault; Mr. Numbers had warned them there would be combat. He’d even had a passing thought of trying to find a place to absorb energy, but he couldn’t bring himself to do it. There was still a nagging voice in the back of his brain telling him that he would lose control and drain the whole school. Or town. Or state.

“I’d like all of you to come down now and meet the professors who will be overseeing the first battle of your college careers, the freshmen combat coaches: Coach George and Coach Persephone!” Dean Blaine announced, gesturing to the side of the stage where a pair of people, both wearing sweats, walked on and joined up with the dean in the center.

The man was dark-haired, tall and muscular. The woman, on the other hand, was blonde, lean, curvy, and just plain sexy. She looked like she wouldn’t be able to take on a sack of potatoes, let alone watch over Supers in combat. Not that that really mattered to the men in the audience, who were staring unabashedly, with only a few exceptions.

Nick was certainly not one of those exceptions. “Look at the tits on her,” he said as he and Vince rose from their seats and began making their way to the stage with the rest of their class.

“You better hope she doesn’t have enhanced hearing,” Vince warned as they descended.

“What? Like she doesn’t know she had amazing tits? I mean, we can



see them through a sweatshirt, I seriously doubt me saying this would result in a groundbreaking realization for her,” Nick defended.

“No, but it could be a skull-breaking one for you. The woman teaches Supers how to fight, I can’t imagine she’s as frail as her form looks,” Vince said.

“You have a point,” Nick agreed. “On the other hand, though... Yowza.”

Fortunately for Vince, at that point they reached the stage and even Nick wasn’t dumb enough to keep chatting about their coach’s breasts with her in human earshot. At least, Vince hoped Nick wasn’t that dumb. Once all the students were together, Coach George stepped forward and addressed them.

“Good morning, new meat,” he said with a grin that was far more believable than the one the dean still had shellacked onto his face. “To the upper classman I’m a professor, but you haven’t earned that right yet, so to you my name is Coach George, and by the end of the year you are going to curse me, my mother for birthing me, and God for allowing me to exist. I am going to work every last one of you down to the bone. I am going to break you apart until you have no concept of what you can or can’t do, because I want each of you to end this year doing things you never thought possible. You will all hate me for the rest of your life, but if you are very skilled and very lucky, you will live long enough to come back here and thank me one day. You will thank me for making you strong enough to survive.”

Coach George stepped back, and Coach Persephone stepped forward. “First off, yes, eyes up at my face, gentlemen. Secondly, I’m going to be training you as well, though while my brutish counterpart will be teaching your bodies how to endure combat, I will be educating your minds. You will use your powers in new ways you never would have imagined before, and you will do it because the only options I am going to hand you are to find a way or suffer bodily harm. You should know that Coach George and I are the harshest instructors in this academy, because we have to be. This is where you are torn down and built up correctly with the building blocks that will enable you to survive the years to follow. If we do not think you can survive, we will fail you. So work hard and learn fast, or you’ll wash out and be no better than a Powered.”

The students winced visibly at that, the idea of being compared to a Powered kicking them into gear and setting their determination not to wash out firmly into place. Which, of course, was exactly what Coach Persephone

had been aiming for.

“All right,” said Dean Blaine. “So, before we pair off for the first round of combat, does anyone have any questions so far?” No hands came up, so Dean Blaine continued. “Fantastic; then I want the girls to go to Coach Persephone and the boys to go to Coach George so they can pair you up.”

“Isn’t that sexist?” The question came from a girl near the front of the crowd with dirty blonde hair. Vince looked at her, and realized with pleasant surprise that the girl with pink-streaked short hair from the dining hall yesterday was standing next to the question asker.

“And what is your name, miss?” Dean Blaine asked in response.

“Julia,” the girl replied.

“Let me guess, Julia; you’re a women’s studies major, right?” Dean Blaine asked.

“Um... yes,” Julia replied.

“There’s always one,” Dean Blaine said with a sigh. “We go over this every year, so I’ll tell you the same thing, Julia. The point of this test is to get an idea of how you fight against an opponent when you are at relatively equal footing. Both you and your opponent will have an ability, so the only other difference is your physique, and sadly, boys are usually stronger than girls. This means that getting an accurate assessment requires us to pair you with people who have similar body types. If it makes you feel better, though, this is only the case for freshman year. Once you become sophomores and have been trained by George here, we’ll be setting you against anyone, regardless of sex.”

“I guess that makes sense,” Julia conceded.

“Great,” Dean Blaine said. “Okay, everyone, now report to your respective coach and get ready for a good old-fashioned tussle.”

## 11.

Vince was impressed at the combat cells that Lander possessed. Seventy feet by seventy feet in size, they were made of reinforced concrete that was several inches thick, with five-inch plastic serving as a window and a triple-locked door the only entrance and exit. What was truly amazing, though, was that there were so many of them. Right now, each member of the freshman class was standing in a cell just like Vince's, staring across at some other student who they would soon be facing off against.

In Vince's case, the boy who had entered was a few inches taller, and a few muscles broader, and a multitude of follicles shorter. His head was perfectly bald, drawing more attention to his striking face and frost-blue eyes. The only other person near them was a girl wearing a white uniform, staring down at them through the glass. She was one of the senior class, doing her duty of watching over the new recruits to make sure no one was killed. Serious injury wasn't a concern since there were healers on hand, but no one could bring back the dead. At least, no one employed by Lander.

Vince and his opponent were both wearing black uniforms of a style similar to the girl watching them. It seemed the hierarchy at Lander was that freshmen wore black uniforms, sophomores and juniors wore grey, and the few seniors that managed to stay in class were issued white uniforms. This supposedly represented the students growing closer to the goodness and purity that all Heroes were meant to represent. Vince thought it was just that there was more training and fighting in the lower years and black didn't stain as easily, but he kept that particular theory to himself.

"Introduce yourselves," came a female voice from a speaker hidden somewhere in the concrete around them. It took Vince a moment, but he realized it had come from his overseer. Apparently there was some sort of intercom system set up for the rooms. It made sense; how else was someone going to talk to them through solid walls?

"My name is Michael Clark," said Vince's opponent, a broad and confident smile smearing across his face.

"Vince Reynolds," said Vince.

"I like your hair," Michael commented.

"I like your... style," Vince reciprocated as best he could.

Michael laughed. "I know it's a bit odd, but you know how that goes,

right? What can I say; I just love feeling the cold air against my head.”

Vince said nothing, merely kept sweeping his eyes over Michael, trying to get some sense of what the boy would be doing once the metaphorical bell sounded. He didn’t have to wait long to find out.

“Begin,” said the same, crackling intercom voice. Vince resisted the urge to look around for the speaker again and that discipline was all that saved him. Before the word was even done being spoken, Michael had reared his right arm back and was punching in Vince’s direction. Granted, since there was forty feet between the two of them, it was a ridiculous gesture that shouldn’t have endangered Vince in the slightest. Vince leapt to the side anyway.

A flash of blue light roared past him, striking the wall where he had been standing only moments before. A quick peek back showed Vince that a long chunk of the wall was now coated in ice. Someone who had cold-based powers. Freaking perfect.

“I’m impressed,” Michael complimented. “Not many people think to get out of the way of a punch from across the room.”

“I try to prepare for the worst case scenario,” Vince admitted.

“Let me know if that helps you,” Michael said as he balled up both of his fists. “Because to be honest, fighting me in the first round is the worst case scenario for anyone.”

Vince didn’t respond this time; instead he took off running. Michael was a good shot with those freezing punches of his, but he was still shooting from forty feet away. Vince was quick on his feet, and more importantly he had a lot of practice at running away, so he was able to stay a few steps ahead of each punch as it went out.

Michael was no slouch either, though; he began looking to where Vince was running and firing ahead of him. More than once Vince was only saved by a quick roll to the side or a slide underneath. The only upside was that the more Michael fired, the more Vince began to get his timing down. Michael needed to take a deep breath between every two punches, though whether it was part of his fighting style or just a necessary moment to recharge Vince was unsure. The good thing was that every time he took that breath, Vince had a moment to pause and see where Michael’s eyes were aiming. The only real chance Vince had was to wear Michael down slowly until his endurance was thin. Using powers still seeming to require him to use physical actions, so if Vince could get Michael gasping for air then he might

have a chance at getting close to him.

Unfortunately, it seemed Michael had figured that out, too.

“What the hell is your power?” Michael asked as he threw two more freezing punches that Vince leapt over. “Running away?”

Vince said nothing, conserving his air for movement, not talking.

“If this is all you can do then you should just give up,” Michael chastised him. “So you’ve got a weak power. That doesn’t mean you should jump around and make an ass of yourself because you’re up against a real opponent.” To punctuate his words, Michael let loose another flurry that crashed at Vince’s feet.

Vince hurdled over the fast-forming ice and kept moving. He realized the problem with his strategy the moment he was away from the slicked ground behind him. The more punches Michael threw, the more ice formed around the room, which made running away increasingly difficult. Already small pillars and blocks of ice were forming where more than one punch had landed. If Vince didn’t bring this to a conclusion soon, he was going to run out of room to dodge.

“Damn it,” Michael cursed. “I don’t care if you can’t fight. Just give up so I can move onto an opponent with some skill.”

Michael threw another right at Vince’s feet, forcing him up into the air, then threw a left punch toward Vince, who was suspended in the mid-jump. On instinct, Vince hurled his upper body forward, turning a midair somersault and dodging the blue blast that would be blaring down below him in mere instants. But the blast didn’t come. Vince crooked his eye back to Michael to see him standing there with an extended left fist and a pulled back right one.

Michael hadn’t used a blast out of his left hand; it had been a feint, which meant he still had one to throw. Michael’s right arm shot back out just before Vince’s feet touched the ground. The concrete below was instantly frozen, impossible to get traction on. Vince was on it only for a moment before his leftover momentum sent him flying onto and across the concrete. As he skidded along the hard surface, Vince tried to think. Michael would have to take a breath now, which meant Vince had maybe an extra second to get to safety. There was no way Vince could scramble up in time; he’d be a sitting target. What other options did that leave him?

As he rolled along the ground, he noticed he was near a moderate-sized block of ice that had been built up by Michael’s attacks. It wouldn’t be

much in the way of cover, but it was a better option than anything else Vince had. Rather than trying to get up, Vince used his window to keep rolling, picking up the speed and veering his course so that he was able to stop himself directly behind the ice block.

The crashing sound of energy accompanied by the cracking sound of growing ice told Vince he had made it just in time. Several more crashes followed, ironically building more ice and reinforcing Vince's defensive wall. Moments later the sounds stopped.

"So you've resorted to hiding now? Is this the best you've got? You must have some kind of ability or you wouldn't be here. How about you try using it?" Michael taunted. "What is it, then, are you just scared of fighting?"

Vince let Michael talk; it bought him precious time. He checked his body and found that aside from a bloody lip, the fall had given him minimal damage. Vince knew he couldn't stay like this for long; it left him utterly vulnerable if Michael were to come around to this side. Michael was still being a bit cautious because he didn't know what Vince's power was, but that wouldn't last forever. The wear-down approach wouldn't work; Michael could destroy the terrain before he got tired. So, in lacking any sort of reliable defense, Vince decided to use the next best thing.

Pure. Offense.

"You seem to be mistaken," Vince said as he pulled himself up carefully from behind the ice block. "Our powers work in contrast to each other, that's why I've been taking the defensive. It was the smart move until I understood your tactics. Let me assure of one thing right now, though."

Vince slowly, deliberately wiped away the blood from his mouth with the back of his fist. "I know how to fight."

## 12.

“Gaaaaah!” Vince cried as he was knocked back across the field, his small body rolling in the grass before coming to a stop.

“How many times do I have to tell you? Learn their timing and adjust your own to fit into their defensive gaps. Most people fight with patterns and that’s all they know. If you can flow through those patterns, they won’t even be able to see how you’re hitting them, let alone find a way to block you,” said a tall, dark-haired man in a tattered red coat.

“Sorry... Father,” Vince squeezed out as he gasped for air. His father’s last punch had knocked the breath out of him. He was used to it, though, and would recover quickly. Father didn’t hold back when teaching him how to fight, because no one Vince ever went up against would be holding back either.

“You’re getting better, Vince,” Father encouraged. “You landed two punches onto my arms that time before you fell into your own rhythm.”

Vince managed to pull himself to his feet. Small and slight at eight years old and wearing ragged clothing, the only thing remarkable about the boy standing in the field was his tousled silver hair. That, and the look of determination screaming out his soft blue eyes.

“How do I keep from falling into my rhythm?” Vince asked.

“Simple,” Father replied. “Don’t have one.”

“I don’t know how,” Vince admitted. Father never chastised him for admitting ignorance, saying it was the only way for Vince to find his weak spots and grow stronger.

“It’s not something that’s easy,” Father explained. “You have to be able to adapt to your opponent’s style, to work in a way that is the most detrimental to them. The only way to achieve it is through proper training and a variety of skilled opponents. However, you have a slight advantage in this area.”

“What’s that?” Vince asked curiously.

“Your power is that of absorption. You can deal in all different types of energies; that means that your core nature is an adaptive one,” Father said. “You were built to handle all kinds of different challenges, so I have faith you’ll be able to learn how to fight without a form.”

“How does my ability factor in?” Vince asked harshly. “I can’t even control it unless you’re around.”

“Just because you can’t control it doesn’t mean it doesn’t say a lot about you,” Father pointed out. “Now, the train will be pulling out in two hours, so if want to jump on a car we only have an hour and a half left. Do you want to spend it whining, or do you want to spend it training?”

Vince took a deep breath, making sure he had fully recovered from the blow to his stomach and losing his wind. He hadn’t, but it was good enough for the moment.

“Training,” Vince said with a grin.

\* \* \*

Ten years later found Vince charging across partially-frozen concrete, ducking blue blast blows as they flew toward him, making a beeline for his enemy as he put all of Father’s training into use. Vince knew Michael’s pattern and knew that any freezing attack would have to be concluded in a two-punch combo. More than that and Michael needed a breath. Vince also knew that while Michael’s style so far had been long range, the way he held himself and threw his blasts were indicative of someone comfortable with close range fighting. Michael definitely had training, and from the way he had been attacking, Vince was betting it was in boxing.

Vince sidestepped another blast as he circled, closing the gap between himself and Michael. It was harder to dodge the closer Vince got, but he’d learned to dodge boxing blows at close combat range; there was no way a punch with a lag time was going to hit him. The problem would be that once Vince closed the gap entirely, he wouldn’t be able to take a single one of Michael’s punches or this match would be all over. Normally he could just count on his practice taking blows to let him work through the pain, but getting frozen solid wasn’t something you could grit your teeth and push through.

Then, all at once, Vince realized he was in range to actually strike back and every cohesive thought was gone from his mind. All he saw was his opponent’s movements, feeling the pattern that Michael wove to take down his prey. Vince flowed around Michael, using footwork to keep Michael from being able to get off a clean shot. At the same time Vince began lightly throwing his own punches. Mere taps at first, easy to recover from for both parties. Vince wasn’t trying to do damage: he was trying to see how Michael blocked. The more soft blows Michael avoided, the surer Vince was that Michael’s training was in boxing, which told Vince exactly how to take him



off guard.

Vince slid to Michael's side and threw a left directly at Michael's face. Michael blocked it immediately, rearing back his own left to deliver an ice punch to Vince's face. He never got the chance, though, as Vince followed the momentum of the punch through with a hard knee to Michael's ribs. Without stopping, Vince used the force to push himself around to Michael's back, out of range of his frozen fists, and deliver a right-handed blow to same spot on the ribs he had struck with his knee. Vince was preparing to let fly a punch to the back of Michael's head when the ground beneath his feet suddenly went slick.

Vince backed away quickly, getting on to a part of the concrete that offered more traction at the sacrifice of his position behind Michael. This had obviously been Michael's plan - he must have punched the ground to steal Vince's footing - but Vince had no other option besides playing into it.

"I can't believe it," Michael said. "All that fucking running and it turns out you have some decent hand-to-hand skills. I'll admit I did not see that coming."

Vince noticed Michael was talking but not punching. Maybe he was foggy from the blows, but Vince doubted it. More likely he had either realized he couldn't hit Vince at this range, or he was trying to lure Vince into relaxing and letting his guard down.

"Of all the things I expected today, using this on someone who hasn't even shown me their power wasn't one of them," Michael said. His tone was casual but his eyes were hard. Vince had embarrassed him, and it was very clear Michael did not take kindly to that. "You got in some good shots, Vince, but that won't work on me anymore."

As he spoke, Michael's body seemed to grow blue. After a second Vince realized that ice was forming over Michael's frame, cracking and fissuring as it went to allow movement, while thickening to protect what was underneath. It seemed to take no time until Michael was almost totally covered in his ice armor. Vince could still make out his eyes through a pair of slits, but there was no way he was going to find a vulnerable chunk of Michael's flesh to pound on this time.

"You did pretty good for being as weak as you are," Michael goaded. "But I want you to see what a real warrior looks like. I'm going to be the number one ranked in this class, because no one is as powerful as me!" Michael tilted back his armored head and laughed, unconcerned about his worthless opponent as he stood in the invincible protection his ice offered

him.

The moment Michael's head was back, Vince began charging forward. He'd made it halfway there when Michael noticed his headlong sprint.

"You think this is for show? Or are you so dumb you really think you can punch through several inches of ice?" Michael asked, taking his stance once again as Vince drew closer.

Vince never slowed down for an instant, running right up to Michael and stopping on his left foot, letting the speed carry his right forward into a powerful side kick. Michael moved to block it, but the foot drew back a few inches before it would have struck the armor around his arm. Vince kept spinning, though, pulling off a complete three-sixty before planting his right down and launching forward on it. Michael realized that Vince was still carrying most the momentum from the run in his body, and that he was cocked back to throw a punch right at Michael's face. It took everything Michael had not to laugh at this sad, determined idiot. So Vince wanted to break his own hand just trying to land a blow on Michael? Well, that was just fine by Michael's standards; he knew how powerful his ice was. Michael didn't even make a motion to block. Let Vince give it his all and fail miserably.

Vince kept moving forward, stopping just short of bouncing into Michael's chest and throwing the rest of his momentum into his right fist, just as Michael had expected. Vince furrowed his brow in concentration; he would have to time this just right. Vince's punch soared upward, on a dead track for Michael's jaw. A fraction of a second before it hit, though, to Michael's tremendous surprise, a fireball roared forth from the clenched fist, striking the icy covering an instant before Vince's flesh.

Black and white spots flashed in front of Michael's eyes as he landed on his back. He couldn't understand it. Vince had hurled a fireball to melt and weaken his armor before the punch connected, that much was obvious. But if Vince had that sort of power, why had he played defensive for so long? One thing was certain; Michael was done taking it easy on this kid.

Michael rose to his feet, reinforcing the area around his chin that Vince's fire had melted. Michael had no banter or sass this time, only unadulterated hatred in his eyes for the boy who had put him on his back.

"Crap," Vince said from the same spot he had knocked Michael back. "I was really hoping that would put you down for the count."

"It didn't," Michael replied.



## 13.

Vince woke up an hour or so later in the healing clinic. He blinked as his eyes adjusted to the lighting and stretched slowly to banish the discomfort that had accumulated in his back from sleeping on the hard bed.

“Oh thank god, you’re finally awake,” said a female voice to his right.

Vince pulled himself up to a sitting position and looked over. Resting on an identical bed was a tall girl wearing a black uniform similar to his. She had the lean, firm look of a track star and held herself, even while sitting, with a sense of poise and control. The most striking feature about her, though, was the bright pink streaks running through her otherwise dark hair.

“Was I out long?” Vince asked.

“Given that you were pretty much a hunk of solid ice when they brought you in, no, I’d say you slept an appropriate amount,” the girl replied as she smirked.

“Solid ice, huh?” Vince said. “I seem to have recovered pretty nicely.”

“Heat lamp and some healing. It’s a dynamite combo,” the girl quipped. “I guess sleep is part of it, too, but damn it was boring having no one to talk to.”

“Sorry about that,” Vince apologized without being sure why. “Why are you hanging around here, though? Didn’t they heal you already?”

“Yeah,” the girl said. “But they told me I had to rest in here until this afternoon at least.”

“Why?” Vince asked.

“Some bullshit about fifteen broken bones needing to rest for a few hours even with healing,” the girl explained. “I’m Sasha, by the way. And before you say anything, I know it’s an old woman name, so keep the jokes to a minimum.”

“I wouldn’t have dreamed of it,” Vince lied. “My name is Vince. How’d you break fifteen bones?”

“I lost my fight,” Sasha replied with a shrug.

“Well, that does make a certain amount of sense,” Vince said agreeably. “What type of ability were you fighting?”

“Some chick that can turn into solid steel,” Sasha said.

Vince let out a low whistle. “That’s a good one.”

“Yup, especially when she waited until I was charging her at super speed to do her little shift. Kicking steel at a few hundred miles an hour... yeah, it kind of sucks,” Sasha said. “So, how about you? I know you were fighting an ice dude, but what do you do? And while we’re not on the subject, but I’m still going to ask anyway, who does your hair?”

“I absorb and redistribute energy, like absorbing the flame from a match and then shooting it out of my thumb. As for the hair, my genetics are my stylist,” Vince said.

“Sweet ass,” Sasha said. “So if you can pack away the fire then it must have been one hell of a fight with you and Frosty.”

“Um, sort of,” Vince said awkwardly. “I kind of forgot to charge up before coming in today, so I was working with less than I would have liked.”

“Hey, no need for excuses. We’re both losers here,” Sasha said. She pulled out a lighter from the back pocket on her uniform and tossed it over to Vince.

“I don’t smoke,” Vince said.

“Which makes you look way less cool when standing around outside, but I didn’t give it to you so you could light up,” Sasha said.

“Then what’s it for?” Vince asked.

“You used all your energy in the fight, right?” Sasha said right back.

“Well, yeah. Did I tell you that?” Vince was growing more confused.

“No, but I figured you wouldn’t have been a guysicle if you had any juice left. So I thought you might need a recharge,” Sasha explained through her transparent exasperation.

“Oh, I couldn’t,” Vince said quickly. “I usually drain all the energy and fuel when I do it, so your lighter would be useless.”

“It came in a pack of twenty for five bucks. I’ll be okay with the loss. Besides, I’ve never seen that ability before. I’ll trade a lighter for a show,” Sasha said.

Vince wanted to protest more, but the truth was he did feel stiff and listless. He remembered how draining the matches had made him feel a bit

better the day before and his aching muscles throbbed again. Vince had spent nearly all of his life with at least a little energy stored up. He was beginning to wonder if the recent constant fatigue had been not a side effect of the experiments done to him, but rather a side effect from constantly running on empty.

With only slight trepidation, Vince flicked the lighter on with his left hand. With his right he reached out to it, forging a connection to the energy leaking out from the metal-topped plastic container. The flame jerked toward him and began flowing in. The lighter had far more potential energy than a single match, so it took a few seconds before it ran dry and the light of the flame vanished. Vince stretched again, noting that the soreness had definitely decreased. He also felt a bit more awake and alert. The lighter had packed significantly more juice than half a pack of matches.

“That was pretty cool looking, I have to admit,” Sasha commented.

“Thanks,” Vince said. “I think I needed that more than I thought. You want the lighter back?”

“Keep it,” Sasha said. “Dead lighter isn’t much use to me, you know?”

“That I do,” Vince agreed. “So, are they going to tell us when everyone is done fighting, or do we just rest until we feel like we should go?”

“Oh, you’re free to go anytime,” Sasha told him. “If you hurry you might still catch the last of the boys’ matches.”

“What about the girls?” Vince asked.

“Those wrapped up, like, half an hour ago. My roommate already texted me some of the rankings,” Sasha said.

“How’d you do?” Vince couldn’t imagine a girl with super speed had fared too poorly.

“Nineteen out of twenty-two,” Sasha said glumly. “That steel bitch took me down in the first round. Even Julia did better than me.”

“That sucks,” Vince said. “Is Julia your roommate?”

“Yeah, and number fourteen in the ranking,” Sasha said. “She made it to the second round, but then she got put down hard. They couldn’t really dock her too many points for it, though. I mean, the broad who beat her did wind up ranked number one for the girls.”

“Who was that?” Vince asked out of curiosity.

“I haven’t met her yet,” Sasha said. “But Julia told me it was some telekinetic girl named Mary.”

## 14.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport sat at Dean Blaine's desk, looking across the sleek mahogany surface at his unapologetic scowl. The lights in Dean Blaine's office were fluorescent and bright, like a compromise between high beams and lamps. The décor was stark, with little more than a diploma and a few awards adorning the four walls around them. Mr. Transport had a vaguely uncomfortable feeling but was unsure how to place it. Mr. Numbers, on the other hand, had been something of a hellion during his younger days and knew immediately why this sensation was both unenjoyable and familiar. It felt almost exactly as if he was once again fourteen years old and sitting in the principal's office, trying desperately to figure which crime he had been discovered at.

"When I agreed to host your students," Dean Blaine began at last. "I did so with the understanding that these were unfortunate children who were being provided with an opportunity to get some measure of control in their otherwise hectic lives. These were Powereds that had been spurned by fate and society alike, yet now that they could actually use their abilities, they wanted to become Heroes and give something back to the world. That was the way your organization pitched them, correct?"

Mr. Numbers cleared his throat. "Well, we aren't really consulted in matters of marketing and diplomacy, but I will admit that does sound like something our company would say."

"Regardless of who said it, you two are the representatives that I have at hand, so you are going to have to be answerable for your company as a whole," Dean Blaine said. "Which brings me to why I called you down here to my office." He slid a piece of paper onto the smooth polished surface of his desk. "Would one of you like to guess what that is?"

Mr. Transport took the paper first, since he had the longer arms and could reach. "It appears to be a ranking of the freshman female students entering your program," Mr. Transport said after a quick glance.

"Correct," Dean Blaine agreed. "Now will you read for me the first name on that list?"

"Mary Smith," Mr. Transport said. He was very thankful he had worked so hard for long at keeping all emotions, including surprise, out of his voice when needed.

"You nailed it," Dean Blaine said with a very out-of-place smile.



“Now, for the last question. Can you please explain to me how a girl who had almost no control over her abilities until a few months ago managed to wipe the floor with every other freshman we put her up against?”

“In all fairness, just because she won doesn’t mean she wiped the floor with them,” Mr. Numbers jumped in.

“I saw her last fight, which was coincidentally her longest, myself,” Dean Blaine said. “It lasted all of twenty two seconds and was against a girl who transformed into solid steel.”

“How did Mary beat that?” Mr. Numbers asked with genuine interest.

“She forced her opponent halfway through the concrete wall, face first. We were forced to remove the girl before she suffocated,” Dean Blaine explained.

“Given their respective powers, that seems like the best method she had,” Mr. Transport said.

“Oh, the strategy was sound, no one could question that,” Dean Blaine acknowledged. “The problem is that no girl her age should be able to generate that much telekinetic force, let alone one whose abilities have been fully-functioning for only a few months. Forcing a human being made of steel through several inches of concrete at point-blank range is a feat that only those who have been training for decades are able to pull off. There are certified Heroes that couldn’t have managed to accomplish that so effortlessly.”

“So, if I am to understand you, you’re concerned about why Mary is so much stronger than she should be,” Mr. Numbers said carefully. He desperately wished he had his usual calculations running through his head so he could jump ahead of the conversation, but unfortunately around Dean Blaine that was impossible.

“I am concerned that you did more than just *help* these children!” Dean Blaine exclaimed as he rose from his seat. “I am concerned that perhaps your company, under the guise of feeling sorry for these dregs of the world, decided that they wouldn’t just give the kids control, they would amplify the children’s powers a bit. After all, they’ve already agreed to be guinea pigs, why not run them through every experimental procedure you’ve got?”

From the way the dean was panting and gesturing it was very apparent to both Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport how much harm the dean believed a little extra testing could do.

“I can assure you that is not the case,” Mr. Numbers said. “Even if the doctors and nurses were not heavily monitored during the children’s treatment, which they were, the company has never successfully found a way to amplify a person’s natural abilities, Super or Powered.”

“Until a few months ago I was under the impression that no one had ever found a way to turn Powered into Supers, so you’ll forgive me if I’m a bit skeptical of your assurances on the lack of existing technology,” Dean Blaine said. He did seem a bit pacified, though, at least enough to retake his seat.

“Be that as it may, it is the truth,” Mr. Numbers said. “All our company did was give Mary the ability to control the power she already had. Perhaps it was just that she was born with a very strong ability and is only now learning to use it.”

“It is... possible,” Dean Blaine conceded. “And for the girl’s sake, I hope that’s the truth of it.”

“What do you mean?” Mr. Transport said, a bit more harshness to his voice than he wanted. The dean wouldn’t notice, and Mr. Numbers would scold him for tipping his hand even slightly, but he couldn’t help it. Mr. Transport had been put here to control but also to protect the students in his dorm. Responding with harshness to a perceived threat was a natural reaction. As it turned out, though, it was an unwarranted one.

“I mean that for a girl that young to be that powerful there are only two options... if one discounts the possibility of outside enhancers,” Dean Blaine said, not without some suspicion lingering in his voice.

“Which we are,” Mr. Numbers replied without missing a beat.

“Yes... Anyway, the only ways she could be that strong are if she was born with a tremendous gift or if she put herself through an unimaginably hellish training,” Dean Blaine said.

“What sort of training?” Mr. Transport asked.

“Well, most telekinetics are also telepaths. Something to do with the part of the brain that gets the power,” Dean Blaine said. “Anyway, many of those with the advanced mind ability train up their telekinesis by learning to sharpen their focus. The better they can focus, the more power they can use and the faster it comes. One of the more popular methods of training is to open up their telepathy as much as they can bear and try to function constantly under the barrage of voices. It helps them learn to focus on tasks at hand and blot out the ambient noise that’s always assaulting them.”

“Interesting,” Mr. Numbers said, praying silently that Mr. Transport wasn’t giving anything away on his face. “I had never heard of that.”

“You wouldn’t have,” Dean Blaine said. “It’s really only something you know of if your job is training Supers day in and day out.”

“So, some of the more powerful ones must be able to blot out a lot of noise,” Mr. Numbers said casually. “What’s the most you’ve heard of someone being able to function with?”

“Well, of course I don’t know what all of them do, but the best I’ve personally witnessed was a Hero who could still function while hearing all the thoughts around him in a three mile radius,” Dean Blaine said. “He’s a top notch one, too, can do some amazing things with that brain of his.”

Neither Mr. Transport nor Mr. Numbers responded. At that moment they had glanced at each other and were having another of their standard silent conversations. There wasn’t much to say in the way of details, merely a subtle sense of panic and surprise. Unbeknownst to Dean Blaine, the company Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport worked for had done a similar radius test on Mary in their pre-program evaluation.

Mary’s range was five miles, and she was able to function perfectly normally while listening to all of that in a populated city.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport quickly excused themselves.

## 15.

“You’re sure it’s okay for you to be walking?” Vince asked as they made their way down the steel and concrete hall.

“No, but I think they were mainly worried about me breaking the sound barrier, not going to the main hall to check the results,” Sasha replied. Julia had texted her that the boys’ fights were finished, but rather than getting the results from her roommate, Sasha had cajoled Vince into seeing for himself.

“Well... okay,” Vince said reluctantly. “Just let me know if you need to lean on me or something.”

“I bet you say that to all the mending girls with super speed,” Sasha said.

“Only the ones with pink and black hair,” Vince shot back.

“Good answer, Silver. Good answer.” Sasha might have continued their verbal dance, but at that point they stepped out of the tunnel and into the main hall. It was really more of an entrance foyer than anything else. Conveyor systems that ran to the respective dorms were on one side, while an enormous screen was perched overhead on the opposite end of the room. There were various hallways like the one Vince and Sasha were emerging from branching off, and at the moment there was a tremendous cluster of black-uniformed freshmen under the screen, looking eagerly for their name in the listings.

The screen was split into two sections currently, boys’ list and girls’ list. Most of the attention was geared towards the boys’ listings, but in fairness, the girls had been finished for at least an hour or so. Vince and Sasha made their way into the rabble of freshman and began their short search of the boys’ list. It took Vince a few minutes to find his name, not because the list was enormous or complicated, but because he was looking in the wrong part of it. When he couldn’t find himself in the bottom section, he finally looked to the higher rankings, though he was utterly unprepared for what awaited him there.

“Eighth?!” Vince exclaimed. “How the hell am I eighth? There are, like, thirty guys and I went down in the first round. Was there a mistake?”

“It isn’t just about how many fights you were in,” Sasha said soothingly. “They were also evaluating how you used your abilities against

the ones you were fighting, how you dealt with their techniques, and how well you thought on your feet. If you were fighting a really lopsided battle and still managed to show solid skills then that was factored in.”

“Yeah but still... eighth?” Vince sighed and tried to relax. It was a good thing; a high ranking was something he should be proud of. He’s been a Powered until two months ago and here he’d managed to show up twenty-two Supers by outdoing them. It was an accomplishment. Vince just wished it was one he felt as though he had earned.

“Didn’t you say the guy you fought was named Michael?” Sasha asked.

“Yeah.”

“Looks like he made it to number three,” Sasha said, pointing up at the list. Vince checked for himself and sure enough she was right. Michael Clark was the third strongest male there, below the number one slot, Chad Taylor, and the number two slot, Shane Desoto. Vince was about to look away when the name in the number five slot caught his eye.

“Who is Roy Daniels?” Vince asked.

“According to Julia, the sexiest man she’s seen in years,” Sasha said. “She keeps texting my ass about him. Also he’s number five.”

“I wonder if he has a brother,” Vince speculated. “One of my dorm mates is named Hershel Daniels.”

“Hershel, huh? I don’t see him up there,” Sasha said.

It was true, Vince looked and looked but Hershel’s name didn’t appear anywhere on either list. Nick was listed at number thirty on the boys’ side and Alice had come in just below Sasha at twentieth on the girls’, but try as they might, the only Daniels they could find on the board was Roy.

“Weird,” Sasha said at last. “Do you think Roy is Hershel but they messed up his name?”

“I somehow doubt it,” Vince said. “Nothing against Hershel, he seems like a really nice guy, but he isn’t the type that your roommate would be constantly texting about.”

“How do you know? Maybe he’s Julia’s type,” Sasha said, a glimmer of antagonism in her voice.

“Does she like LARP and table top games? Because that’s what

Hershel told us he loves to do in his free time,” Vince countered.

“Oh. No. Totally a different dude,” Sasha agreed quickly. “Well, whatever; just ask him about it when you get back to your dorm.”

“I’ll have to,” Vince said. “Especially since none of my fellow Melbrook residents seem to have hung out after they saw their ranks.”

“No worries, I bet they lick their wounds in time for Casino Night,” Sasha said optimistically.

“Casino Night?” Vince asked.

“Yeah, there are flyers up all over the dorms,” Sasha said.

“Must have missed them,” Vince said, doing his best to sound casual in the deflection.

“It’s in the student union tonight at seven,” Sasha explained. “Free food, fake gambling with free chips that you can use for raffles, and all the karaoke you can handle. Supers and Normals are both invited.”

“That sort of sounds like fun,” Vince said.

“Yeah, we can meet more fellow freshman. Maybe we’ll even make a friend or two that can’t lift a bus or melt steel,” Sasha said.

“Very true,” Vince agreed. “I don’t really know anyone here except my dorm mates. Oh, and now you, too.”

“Same boat,” Sasha said. “I met Julia because she’s my roommate, but you’re the only other friend I’ve made so far. Combat doesn’t really engender communal feelings on the first day.”

“Maybe that’s why they do it,” Vince speculated.

“Point,” Sasha said. “Well, I’m going to head back up to the dorm. Seven is only a few hours away and I am desperate for a shower. You think you’ll go to the Casino Night?”

“Positive.”

“Sweet,” Sasha said, pulling out the “e” sound a bit. “Want to meet up at the entrance and then lose all our fake money together?”

“Absolutely,” Vince said. “I’ll see if I can talk any of my dorm mates into coming along.”

## 16.

Nick was already seated comfortably at a blackjack table when he noticed Vince and some pink-haired girl walk into the garishly decorated student union. They had obviously been trying for an over-the-top Vegas style décor with the gold banners and fake statues, but what the decorator had failed to realize was that Vegas' brilliance was in the subtlety beneath the glamour. Nick took no offense to it, though; that was the signature appeal of his home town. Often imitated, never duplicated.

Nick was grateful that Vince had told him about the event at any rate. Throwing his first fight to stay off anyone's radar had left an unpleasant taste in his mouth. Tactics and stealth were all well and good, but there was something so viscerally wrong about losing in any way. It had been necessary, though, and as Nick pulled in a few more additions to his pile of chips he felt the sourness ease from his taste buds. It didn't matter that the chips were worthless: it only mattered that Nick was winning.

"Hit," said a female voice next to him. Nick had been seated and working up a hot streak when Mary had plunked herself down next to him. He didn't want to be rude, but he didn't want a mind reader so close to him, either. He had waffled for a few moments then let it be. The girl could follow him even if he did get up; besides, he had no idea how good her range was. Even being in the same building might give her free access to his head. Better to stay put and keep up appearances of friendliness toward his dorm mates. It wouldn't fool her, but that was a lost cause anyway.

"Good play," Nick complimented her as a ten was laid onto her queen, giving her twenty.

"The advice helps," Mary replied without looking at him. This was the first time they had spoken all night. He took her meaning quite clearly.

"Glad to help," Nick lied, turning his attention back to the game. He was almost immediately interrupted again.

"Whoa," Vince said as he came up to the table. "That's quite a stack you've acuminated."

"Well, I am from Vegas, after all," Nick said.

"And eighteen," Vince countered. "So you couldn't have hit the casinos. How'd you get so good at blackjack?"

"Chill, Vince, it's a game of luck," the pink-haired girl interrupted.

There was a beat of silence as Nick could actually watch the word luck leave her lips and enter Vince's head. Once there it plunked around a few times before finally coming to rest in a spot labeled "natural conclusion."

"Yeah," Vince said as his eyes narrowed. "You're right, Sasha; it is a game of luck." The sense of accusation wasn't precisely dripping from Vince's words, but there was definitely some accusatory condensation on them.

"So it's Sasha? I'm Nick and this is Mary. We're both in Melbrook with Vince. I do apologize for my good friend's poor manners in not introducing us," Nick said, switching into his usual affable mode and swinging the focus away from his blackjack success.

"Nice to meet you two," Sasha said, giving a slight incline of her head.

"Sasha, would you mind grabbing us a seat at the craps table? I know we wanted to roll some dice, I just need to have a quick word with my dorm mate," Vince said.

Sasha looked at the two of them for a moment, then shrugged and said, "Okay." She wandered off towards the craps, but not without keeping an eye on them. That girl was sharper than she wanted to let on. Nick could respect that.

"Nick," Vince whispered harshly as soon as Sasha was gone. "Do you really think it's a good idea to be doing... what you're doing out in the open like this?"

"You mean winning?" Nick asked innocently.

"I mean using an unfair advantage."

"Hold your horses there, hoss," Nick said in equally low tones. "First off, this isn't even real money, so stay off the soapbox. Secondly, I'm not doing what you think I'm doing. I'm winning because I know how to play blackjack well. There are some basic strategies any kid who grew up around a city of gambling knows. So re-fucking-lax and go worry about your date instead of your dorm mate."

"It isn't a date," Vince snapped immediately. "And... I'm sorry. You're right. I guess I was just worried because... well, the whole secret being a big portion of your grade thing. You really haven't been using?"

"Ask Mary," Nick replied. "See if I've focused or breathed deep even



once tonight.”

Vince looked at Mary, who didn’t turn toward him but shook her head to the negative anyway. “Sorry,” Vince said once more. “I guess that whole speech and a day of fighting has gotten me paranoid.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Nick assured him. “If I were you I’d think the same thing. Now go catch up to your girl before someone else does.”

“She’s not my girl,” Vince said, but he departed from their table and made his way over to Sasha and the craps game. Nick turned back to the blackjack table, annoyed that he had missed several hands while talking to Vince and had now lost track of the cards.

“I notice you didn’t bother to mention to him that you don’t actually need to breathe deep or close your eyes to use your talent,” Mary said softly.

“It wasn’t pertinent,” Nick defended. “After all, I’m really not doing anything.”

“You don’t consider counting cards doing anything?” Mary asked.

“Fine; I’m not doing anything that others couldn’t do with skill and practice. Besides, for all you know, I do need to shut my eyes to use my talent. Maybe that’s why I wear the sunglasses.”

“No, it isn’t,” Mary said with unfaltering certainty.

Nick was ruffled by how sure she was. It was unnerving, talking to someone he couldn’t bluff. He wanted to know more about what she could see, but was afraid of how much he would be exposing of himself. He shrugged off the fear. In for a dime, in for a dollar.

“How much do you know?” Nick asked flatly as he slid several chips out to place a bet.

“Enough,” Mary replied as she followed suit and put her own chips into play. “More than you want me to, which isn’t saying much, but less than you’re scared I do, which also isn’t saying much.”

The dealer put two cards in front of each of them, so they each paused to do a quick spot of mental math.

“Have you told anyone?” Nick asked.

“No,” Mary replied. “And I won’t, either. I’ve been hearing stuff I wasn’t supposed to all my life. I learned a long time ago it’s best if I treat it like a therapist or an attorney, with ironclad confidentiality.”

“Is that supposed to assure me?” Nick asked as he rapped knuckles against the green velvet and the dealer handed him another card. An almost instantaneous calculation flew through his head and he waved off to show he was staying.

“It’s supposed to let you know where I stand,” Mary replied, tapping her own hand as well. She went for another hit after the first then elected to stay.

“And where is that?” Nick asked as the dealer began hitting his own stack, stopping once he struck eighteen.

“As your friend,” Mary replied. “Someone you can talk to and trust. Someone who understands some of the things you’ve gone through.”

“Table has eighteen,” the deal announced. The girl to Nick’s right had already busted, so Nick was first to be compared to the dealer’s numbers.

“Nineteen,” Nick announced. To Mary, he resumed his whispering tone. “You’ll forgive me if I’m a bit reluctant to take you up on that. I’ve got trust issues.”

“No problem,” Mary whispered back. “Twenty,” she announced happily, smiling at all of the other players at the table. Both of them pulled in the chips they had won and pushed a few more out for the next round.

“I’m just saying,” Mary resumed in her soft tones. “I’m going to be in on just about everything you do anyway. I thought that since there is finally someone you can’t lie to, maybe you’d like to try talking to them. It’s not as if you have to worry about giving away something I don’t already know.”

Nick couldn’t think of a snappy comeback for this one, so instead he just checked his cards. He hated himself for realizing that Mary was right, and he hated her even more because the moment he thought it a small smirk crept onto her face.

## 17.

Alice was bored. She had come along to the Casino Night with the rest of her dorm, with the exception of Hershel, whom no one had seen since the beginning of the day, but the truth was she had little taste or stomach for craps. There was no nuance to it: just chunk the dice and pray for the best. Alice preferred her games more... strategic.

She stood next to Vince and the pink-haired girl he seemed to be getting along with so well - Sasha was her name, if Alice recalled correctly - as they all watched and occasionally participated in the craps game. Her poor luck on her few attempts had hardly endeared her to the game, and that, coupled with the events of the day, were all contributing to her increasingly sour mood.

Alice tried to smile and keep her facade plastered up by focusing on the positive. It wasn't as if she had really expected to fare well in the combat trials in the first place. She could only fly, while a significant majority of the girls here had abilities that were far more fighting-based. Still, she had been downed in her first round in less than a minute by some girl with sonic blasting powers. It had hurt, and despite all the preparation she had given herself to brace for the inevitable loss, Alice had found that once the match was done, her pride was stinging a bit as well. It certainly hadn't helped matters when she learned Mary had come out as top of the class. Still, Alice was an academic at heart, and being a Hero wasn't just about how many cars you could throw in a minute. It was also about wit, resourcefulness, and intelligence, all of which Alice was confident she could use to elevate her own status. Eventually.

Alice abandoned the craps table when she heard Vince and Sasha making plans to meet for breakfast the next morning before heading off to class. They would all be spending their mornings attending their aboveground classes, but the afternoon would find them all down in the secret levels, training up on the things that really mattered. Vince and Sasha both seemed excited about what the next day would hold, which told Alice that they knew nothing of what was actually in store. She did, and she had the good sense to dread it. Alice left the two to their slowly-blooming, obvious romance and wandered across the room to find some entertainment of her own.

She passed Nick and Mary whispering in hushed tones at the blackjack table. If it had been anyone else but Mary, Alice might have lingered to see what they were discussing. With a telepath, though, there was too much risk of giving away more information than she gained. Instead Alice

trudged across the room, passing by the happy faces while wearing one of her own. Eventually she found herself at the only part of the Student Union that allowed for seating without participation: the karaoke stage. Some blonde girl Alice recognized from the program was wailing her way through a pop song as Alice gently plunked down in the back. Ignoring the warbling, Alice pulled out her phone and began checking her e-mail. It was bad form to appear so antisocial in a public place, but she needed a moment to gather her thoughts and get into the right frame of mind. A few minutes by herself would be a relatively small concession for being able to mingle and socialize the rest of the night.

Alice was so caught up in actively ignoring the poor blonde on stage that she didn't even notice when the song ended. She didn't notice the mild applause or the announcement of the next song either. What she, along with everyone else in range of the speakers, did notice was what followed. A husky male voice vibrated across the room, breaking into the deep opening chords of a country song. Alice didn't listen to country, and for the life of her couldn't have told you what the song was. At that moment, though, she couldn't hear anything else in the room. Shoving the phone hastily back into her pocket, Alice turned all of her attention to the boy – no, the man – who had pulled a stool on stage and was seated on it as he crooned into the microphone.

He was tall, that was apparent even though he was sitting. He wore a plaid button-down shirt, a small grey cowboy hat, and a pair of clearly worn-in jeans. There was something oddly familiar about his face, Alice noted, and his body was hard and lean. He was well-muscled as his half-open shirt proudly displayed, but with the flat muscle of an athlete rather than the bulky and superficial kind that body builders acquire. If Alice had to guess, which she was actively doing, she would say he was a quarterback in high school, given his physique and frame. Alice's eyes danced around the crowd, noting their reactions to the clear improvement in entertainment.

A large chunk of the women in the karaoke's audience were staring at this mystery man with unabashed interest, the most fervent being the blonde who had sung before him. Many of the men were trying to seem unimpressed by him and his performance, though a few who must have recognized the song were happily enjoying his rendition. As he sang, the man's own hazel eyes swept the crowd, lingering ever-so-intentionally on the women eagerly looking up at him. They came to rest on his blonde predecessor, who looked as though she was applying all her self-control toward not letting out a squeal.

The song finished, and the man stood from his stool and took a wide bow. There was blatantly more applause than there had been for the girl, yet

as the man walked down from the small platform that was serving as a stage and tipped his hat at the blonde as way of introduction, it seemed like she neither noticed nor cared.

For her part, Alice felt a bit better. Watching a gorgeous man sing had really done nothing for her, except that it had pulled her mind out of its funk and forced her to focus on something else for a while. Settling back in, she felt her problems were somewhat less pressing than they had been before, as is usually the case, and decided she would take a cue from the singing cowboy. This was an event to meet people and make connections: in other words, a social activity. That made it Alice's home turf. She might not be able to beat everyone in combat, but there were few who could work a room like Alice Adair.

Alice rose from her seat and set off.

## 18.

Vince had some trouble finding Hughes Hall the next morning. In his defense, Lander was a very large campus, and he had hardly had free time to explore it. He might have gotten up a bit earlier if he had been thinking ahead, but Casino Night had gone on a lot longer than he expected, and it turned out being frozen solid had left him drained by the day's end. On the plus side, he had won enough chips to put his name in a few raffles. He had even managed to win a clock radio. It wasn't quite as nice as the two hundred dollar gift card Nick had won, but it was something to be happy about.

If Vince had been a bit pettier, he might have accused Nick of rigging the raffle, but given the amount of chips his sunglasses-wearing friend had turned in, it didn't really surprise anyone when Nick's name was drawn. That boy was either cheating up a storm or really knew how to play blackjack. Since he was one of Vince's few friends, Vince was opting to give him the benefit of the doubt. Had Vince been a bit more experienced in the ways of the world, it might have dawned on him that the two options were not mutually exclusive.

Vince was in a good mood, even as he scrambled to find Sasha's dormitory. It was his second day attending Lander and the first day of real classes. He had basic math and literature classes in the morning, followed by gym and Ethics of Heroism in the afternoon. He still wasn't sure why gym was ascribed a three-hour chunk of his time every day, but he assumed there would be a logical explanation when he got there. Besides, he and Sasha were getting breakfast before their morning classes together, which made him just a bit happier than he would admit to anyone who was asking. He did enjoy women with multi-colored hair.

Vince had been polite enough to invite his fellow dorm mates to come along. Nick had said no due to an early class, Mary had politely declined without explanation, and Alice had informed him that she would be avoiding the dorm food as much as was humanly possible. Vince had looked for Hershel as well, but to no avail. It seemed their friend hadn't even come home last night. Vince was beginning to get worried, but he was trying to hope for the best. If he didn't see his portly dorm mate soon, though, Vince was planning on finding Mr. Numbers or Mr. Transport.

Vince saw the bell tower and finally got a sense of where he was. With its lush foliage, sprawling campus, and large buildings, Lander was one of the largest and most scenic colleges in California. All of which sounded great on the brochure, but was somewhat less charming when trying to hustle between

locations across campus. Vince was really hoping he didn't have any classes that were too far apart when he finally saw a sign on a multistoried building that read "Hughes."

He walked into the lobby quickly, checking the wall clock and realizing with a twinge that he was late. It wasn't by much, but it was enough to irk him. He had been taught that punctuality was one of the most important virtues to have. He made his way through the white-tiled entryway and past the door leading into the dorm area itself. Some of the dorms were segregated into male and female, his own being one of them, but Hughes had alternating floors. The rooms were done in suites, with two rooms sharing a common living room area. It engendered a sense of community, or so Sasha had told him, since people could leave their living room doors open and still preserve a getaway in their bedroom. It occurred to Vince that whoever had built Melbrook for him and the others had clearly taken some cues from the Hughes dormitory set up.

In fact, Vince was right. Alice had toured the Lander campus (along with several others) before talking with the architects who would ultimately design Melbrook. She had found the Hughes design an excellent integration of privacy and community, though her original designs had her room set off in a separate area. Specifically, it was in an entirely separate building on the opposite campus and utterly unaffiliated with Melbrook in anyway. That attempt had failed, but she'd considered it something of a long shot anyway.

Vince bounded up the stairs to the second floor and began moving down the hallway. Since the rooms were arranged sequentially, it didn't take him much time at all to find Sasha's room: 216. He was about to knock when he heard shouting from the other side of the door. Vince couldn't quite make out the words, but they definitely sounded angry. There were several voices, at least two female with one probably male. Vince was still standing there, debating on whether he should knock or wait a few moments for things to calm down, when he heard an object land heavily against the door. All thoughts of tact aside, Vince jerked the doorknob, which was fortunately unlocked, and burst into the room.

"Is everyone okay?" Vince yelled before he could take in the scene around him. As the sights the room held registered into his mind one by one, it became clear that things were undoubtedly not okay.

There were two girls and a boy here, all right. The most attention-grabbing one was the blonde that Sasha had pointed out as her roommate yesterday, Julia, who was a few steps outside of her bedroom and into the living room. She was rearing back a large black pump, clearing intending to

send it flying. If Vince had bothered to look down he would have noticed its twin resting by his feet, the obvious culprit in the case of the mysterious thudding noise against the door. Julia was wearing a sizable plaid shirt, though with her arm reared back and pulling the fabric up, it was evident that the shirt wasn't quite sizable enough.

Standing between Julia and the guy, looking haggard and unhappy but playing the referee, was Sasha, wearing a tight pink shirt and grey sleep shorts. Ordinarily Vince would have savored this image a bit more than he did. Unfortunately, his attention couldn't help but be captured somewhat by the other male in the room. He was a heavy guy, wrapped poorly in a towel, and was hunched over in a submissive position. He was clearly trying to defend himself verbally, but from the look on Julia's face, Vince had a feeling the boy hadn't gotten that far.

Leaping into this chaotic scene, as all three pairs of eyes turned on him in surprise, Vince tried to look on the bright side. At least he had found Hershel.



## 19.

“Who the fuck are you?!” Julia screeched at Vince.

“Um, I’m Vince,” he said lamely. “Sasha and I were meeting to go get breakfast.”

“Vince, thank God,” Hershel cried, dashing over to his dorm mate’s side and all but cowering. “This woman has gone mad, she won’t listen to anything.”

“Why are you in a blanket?” Vince asked.

“Why do you know this guy?” Sasha asked.

“WHY WERE YOU IN MY BED?” Julia thundered. Vince was impressed, he would have never thought a girl her size would have pipes like that.

“I keep trying to tell you that. You fell asleep with me,” Hershel said with as much projection as he had. It turns out that wasn’t much, but Julia’s eruption had silenced the room pretty effectively.

“Bullshit I did,” Julia denied. “I was... with... Roy last night. You know, the tall, hard-bodied man that you definitely are not!”

“Can someone please tell me what the hell is going on?” Vince tossed out, hoping to get some sense of what was happening around him.

“I’ve been listening to them for a while,” Sasha said. “I think I understand the gist of it. If you two don’t mind, I’ll recap and we can see where the disagreement is.” Both Hershel and Julia nodded their agreement, though Hershel with gratitude and Julia with barely-suppressed rage.

“Thanks,” Sasha continued. “So, Julia met Roy last night at the karaoke part of Casino Night. They came home and got busy-”

“Get busy? That’s presumptuous,” Julia butted in.

“There was a tie on the door, I slept on the living room couch, and these walls are a lot thinner than you seem to think they are,” Sasha replied succinctly.

“Oh,” Julia said, a bit of the wind leaking out of her sails.

“Whatever, I don’t give a damn, I was just recapping,” Sasha said. “So they were at it for a few hours, kudos to Roy, by the way, then finally passed

out and we all got some sleep. I wake up this morning to her throwing a hissy fit and beating the shit out of the guy in the towel. It seems she and sex-man passed out last night but she and that guy were the ones that woke up together.”

“Which I can explain,” Hershel interjected before Julia could build up to another tirade. “If Vince would please shut the door.” Vince complied and Hershel continued. “I am Roy... technically. He’s the version of me with powers.”

“I thought you were a shifter,” Vince said.

“I am. I shift into Roy. He’s the part of me with abilities. Also charm and confidence,” Hershel admitted a bit sadly.

“And looks,” Julia spat out.

“Hey, now,” Vince said. “There’s no need for that. Hershel didn’t sneak into your room and crawl into your bed. You took him home and he turned back in his sleep.”

“So he couldn’t have warned me?” Julia asked.

“Roy was a bit... preoccupied,” Hershel said, blushing freely.

“Wait, so Roy is a hot, Super version of you?” Sasha asked. “I’m just trying to get a grip on this.”

“Yes and no,” Hershel said. “Same body, with the obvious alterations, but we have entirely different personalities. Roy tends to be... easily distracted.”

“So I was a distraction? Well, why the hell isn’t Roy here explaining all of this?” Julia asked.

“Roy is rarely inclined toward dealing with the morning after,” Hershel said. Without warning, Julia whipped the shoe in a straight path for his head. Sasha knocked it away faster than Vince could see, literally, and Hershel desperately tried to cool the blonde. “It wasn’t just that! There’s a certain trigger that brings Roy out and when it wears off I go back to being me. It was an unavoidable change. I know that Roy liked you very much!”

“He did?” Julia suddenly seemed to calm exponentially. “How do you know? What did he say about me?”

“Well, we don’t talk... not really. But we have access to each other’s memories and what we were thinking or feeling at any given time,” Hershel

explained.

“Oh,” Julia said. “Wait, does that mean you remember everything from last night?”

“Well... yes,” Hershel said, bracing himself for assault. This time though, it was Julia’s turn to go red.

“Ummmmm, well, this clearly seems like just a giant misunderstanding,” Julia said quickly. “Hershel, I’m sorry I threw things at you why don’t you grab your pants I’m going to be in the shower I’ll see you all later.” Without a pause or a breath Julia snatched up a towel from inside her room and bolted out of the living room, on a beeline toward the showers and away from the remaining three.

“Huh,” Sasha said. “That must have been some kinky shit.”

“I’d really like not to comment,” Hershel said as he gathered up the clothes from Sasha and Julia’s bedroom floor.

“Hershel, it doesn’t look like those really fit you,” Vince pointed out.

“They don’t,” he said. “I’ll be able to get home in them, though. Besides, we make it a rule to take care of the other’s clothing whenever possible. It’s a consideration that keeps both of our wardrobes intact.”

“So... still haven’t told me how you know each other,” Sasha pointed out.

“Remember when we saw the name Roy on the boards yesterday and I told you about my dorm mate, Hershel?” Vince asked.

“Ohhh,” Sasha said. “Well, that explains why Hershel wasn’t up there at least.”

Hershel had shut the door to the bedroom and was presumably getting dressed.

“Poor guy,” Vince said. “I can’t imagine this was how he wanted to start his career at Lander.”

“I wouldn’t feel too bad for them. I got a front audio seat for last night’s show and I have a feeling the memories of that experience were worth it,” Sasha said.

“You think your roommate is that good?” Vince asked.

“Maybe, but I also know something you don’t,” Sasha said.

“Do tell.”

“I know that Julia’s power is to make duplicates of herself,” Sasha said.

“Like, illusions or dummies?” Vince asked.

“Like real live, walking, talking, capable of independent action duplicates,” Sasha elaborated.

“Well... imagine that,” Vince said.

“No need,” Hershel replied as he stepped out of the bedroom. It was an awkward ensemble that adorned his body since Roy was clearly taller and leaner, but nothing was bursting so it seemed Hershel was right and he would be able to get back to Melbrook. “I’m afraid I’ll have to apologize, but knowing she has that ability means I’m almost positive Roy will be calling on her again.”

“Just spare me the morning fiasco next time,” Sasha said. “And if possible keep Silver here awake instead of me. Melbrook is probably just as nice a place to get it on.”

“I’ll keep that in mind, but sadly I can make no promises,” Hershel said. “I’ll see you at Melbrook, Vince. Sasha, thank you for your understanding.”

“No worries,” Sasha said with a wave. “I sort of expected this. It is college, after all.”

With a nod Hershel stepped out the door, keeping his eyes peeled for fear of running into Julia, leaving Vince and Sasha alone in the living room area.

“So,” Sasha said after a moment, “you wishing you had talked to the girl that’s a walking orgy instead of the chick with the colored hair?”

“Nah,” Vince replied. “I’ve got a thing for girls in grey workout shorts, so you’re still narrowly in the lead.”

Sasha laughed then looked at what she was wearing. For the first time all morning she became all too aware of just how well her shorts lived up to their name, and the fact that her tight pink shirt wasn’t being hampered by the presence of a bra. The thought riding on the coattails of the previous two was the realization that Vince must be just as aware of these things.

“Ready for food in five!” Sasha yelled as she moved past Vince in a

blur and slammed the door to her bedroom behind her. Vince wished he could have seen her mad dash for cover, but that was the sacrifice you made when you hit on a girl with super speed.

## 20.

Nick had never suspected he would be grateful for assigned seating, but as he took his desk at the end of the row next to a short boy with messy hair, Nick did take a moment to thank his lucky stars. It wasn't that he preferred aisle seats- he had a feeling that no position in the room would liven up Ethics of Heroism - but it did make things a bit easier on him. Nick had known when he chose the cover persona of a happy-go-lucky, chatter-happy dimwit that there would be certain concessions involved. One that he hadn't counted on grating as much as it did was the need to be around his fellow dorm mates constantly, seeking them out and keeping conversations aloft. He'd vested ample time with Vince, but the others were a bit more difficult to wrangle, and of course Mary was a lost cause. Thus, if he had been able to choose his own seat, he would have been forced by his own sense of commitment to take one near his fellow Melbrook residents. Being placed on the end away from them allowed him a measure of alone time without offending his actor's sensibilities.

Nick extracted a binder and a pen from his bag and turned to an untouched section. He already had notes from his economics and accounting classes that morning, so this was his last mind-stretcher of the day. Afterwards came gym, whatever that entailed, and then he would be done with his first day of college. It was pleasant of them to have put it on a Friday at least, allowing the students a chance to acclimate to the town around Lander.

Nick perused the room, taking cursory notes and finding the positions of the others from his dorm. Hershel had finally popped back up that morning, and he was easy to spot as he waded through the rows, awkwardly trying to find his spot. The others took a few minutes to locate since the room was full of the freshman class, all clad in their black uniforms. He managed to locate the final one, Mary, just as the door opened and Dean Blaine walked into the front of the room.

"Good morning, class," Dean Blaine said with a large smile. "As all of you will hopefully remember, my name is Dean Blaine, and I will be teacher for Ethics of Heroism. And before anyone asks, no, you aren't getting special treatment. I consider it my personal pleasure to instruct the new freshmen every year, helping them to understand not just what we do, but why it is so important that we do it."

A hand went up quickly. The class's suck-up, no doubt. Nick knew there would be one: there always was, and of course they couldn't wait to

identify themselves by asking the first question. There was no surprise in Nick that someone was already drawing attention to themselves. What did surprise him was the voice of the question asker. He chided himself for not having anticipated someone that obvious.

“So does that mean you and the two coaches make up the entirety of the Hero Certification Program’s staff?” Alice asked once Dean Blaine pointed to her.

“Certainly not,” Dean Blaine assured her. “There are several more professors on staff here, though you won’t be working under any of them until sophomore year.”

“Why not?” This time the question came from a tall girl with her hair pulled back tightly into a braid. She didn’t bother to raise her hand.

“Well, simply put, you wouldn’t gain anything from them yet,” Dean Blaine explained. “You see, freshman year of this program is the year that we ready your minds and bodies for what is to come over the following three. This is the year that you get the basics, and it’s the year we see how many of you have the determination to see our program through to the end. The other professors will be working with you on more specialized programs, programs that you don’t have the groundwork for yet.”

“See it through?” Alice shot the tall girl who apparently didn’t believe in the courtesy of the hand raise a dirty look.

“Yes,” said Dean Blaine. “The training here is rather grueling, and many who think they want to pursue this line of work soon change their minds once they experience it. The dropout rate of the Hero Certification Program is approximately sixty-five percent. That does not include students who are cut by the staff, either; that number only represents voluntary departures.”

The tall girl let out a low whistle, but ceased her questioning of the dean.

“Anyway,” Dean Blaine continued. “As all of you should know, this will be the only Friday that we meet. Normally this class will only be on Tuesdays and Thursdays, with the other three days allotted for personal study. I’m sure most of you are counting on that as a free period, but I assure you, it is time you should cherish. That is a boon we only provide to the freshmen, to help ease the transition. Now then, on to the syllabus.”

There was a collective sigh that rippled through the class. No one groaned, but it was close.

Dean Blaine laughed. "Same reaction every year. Forgive my little joke, but there won't be a syllabus. This is a discussion class, one for which you will be graded on participation and attendance, but written work doesn't really mesh with the subject matter we're covering. If I asked you for a paper on why Heroes give themselves and their careers to protecting the safety of the people, you'd just be up all night writing words. When I ask you that question, which I will, incidentally, I want to look you in the eye and hear what you really think. So come prepared to talk and think, but otherwise you won't need anything but your wit."

That was a relief to almost everyone else in the class. Nick swore inwardly. Now he'd have to bluff the dean at least twice a week. Of course, he could always answer honestly, but Nick was smarter than he appeared, at least smart enough to know that was a dumb idea. The views Nick had been raised with didn't correlate so well with the rest of society's values. The truth had its place, and it was called a deathbed.

"That brings us to the matter of today. I'm sure many of you are anxious to be off to the next class and find out what gym is all about," Dean Blaine said. There were a few enthusiastic nods around the room; clearly the idea of training openly with their abilities appealed to many of the students. "Well, I commend your curiosity and I'm going to reward it. Today we will be dismissing Ethics of Heroism early to give you all an extra half hour of gym. I think it will give you a proper appreciation."

The rest of the class seemed upbeat as they stowed their binders and began rising from their seats. Nick was a bit more apprehensive. Among all of them, he seemed to be one of the few who noticed that Dean Blaine hadn't told them what exactly they would be getting a proper appreciation of. He tried to assure himself that he was just reading into things too much.

Several hours later, when he finally had the energy to, he admonished himself for not trusting his instincts.



## 21.

“Two-minute break,” Coach George shouted to the freshmen.

“Oh, thank you, dear and sweet merciful lord of heaven,” Hershel gasped. Vince and Nick had a similar sentiment but lacked the breath to express it.

What the course schedule had referred to as “gym” was in fact a tortuous living hell. For the past three hours there had been nothing but nonstop physical exertion. Pushups, sit-ups, weight training, resistance training, all with running in between. There had been a total of five two-minute breaks counting this one, and the rest of the time had been spent constantly active.

Hershel cursed himself for showing up to gym. He knew it had been a stupid idea when he did it, but after the morning’s incidents, he couldn’t bear being Roy again so soon. He had imagined that he would be able to handle whatever physical activities were thrust upon him for at least one day. He had been wrong. He had been oh-so-very wrong.

The only upside was that almost no one was faring well throughout this training. Vince and Nick were both gasping for air beside him as they stopped running, and across the track he could see the girls leaning against the wall, resting with as much vigor as possible. The coaches had separated the boys and girls into two herds at opposite ends of the track, warning that dire consequences would occur if anyone fell so far behind that they wound up in the other sex’s herd. A young-looking boy with messy brown hair had been the only one so far, and Coach Persephone had swept him off to another area. No one wanted to know what he had to do.

Truthfully, though, Hershel wasn’t sure how long it would be before others followed suit. The only reason more hadn’t lagged behind was that both groups were losing speed and stamina at similar rates. Near the head of the boys’ group a bald guy was holding it together pretty well, and next to him was a boy with short blond hair who didn’t even seem to be sweating or breathing hard. Those with physical based powers were kicking ass at life today. Hershel cursed himself again. If Roy were doing this he wouldn’t need a rest at all.

“Why... why did we let Dean Blaine dismiss us early?” Vince asked as he sucked in air.

“We’re idiots,” Nick responded instantly. “He was right, though. I now

have a profound appreciation for Ethics of Heroism.”

Vince and Hershel nodded their agreement. Neither would be fantasizing about another early release any time soon. Or ever, for that matter.

“Time’s up, you over-confident wimps,” Coach George yelled. It couldn’t have been two minutes. There was no way it was two minutes. Hershel felt tears welling up inside him; he couldn’t take any more of this. He was out of shape to begin with; at least the others had some semblance of stamina. Before he could actually lose control, though, Coach George hollered once more.

“Everyone run over here and take a knee.” They followed his instructions quickly, never more happy in their entire lives to sit down on the hard wooden floor than they were at that precious moment. Coach George stood in front of them and Coach Persephone came up next to him. Somewhere inside him, Hershel felt Roy stir at the sight of her. Hershel shoved him down immediately. It was bad enough he was getting dirty looks from Julia all day. The last thing he needed was to be labeled as the student who tried to bang a coach, even if it wasn’t really him that was doing it.

“You did piss poorly today,” Coach George began. “That amount of exercise shouldn’t even faze a Hero, but you all were struggling just to make it to the end. With precious few exceptions, I daresay none of you would have finished if we kept going for the extra thirty minutes.”

Hershel certainly wasn’t going to argue that point and he didn’t suspect any of the other freshmen were either.

“When this year is over, you’re going to look back on today with a sense of nostalgia for how light the workouts were. You’re going to have fantasies that when you come into class we just tell you to run most of the time. This will be the happiest day of your career in gym, because from here on out it only gets worse,” Coach George said. The scariest part of his mini-speech was that he wasn’t yelling or trying to put fear into them. He seemed to be sincerely warning them, which made it all the more terrifying.

“Now, before I hand things off to Coach Persephone to talk about how the rest of this year will work, there are two people I want to see up front. Chad Taylor and Mary Smith, get up here.”

Mary made her way slowly over to the front. She was dripping with sweat and still breathing hard, but she seemed to have held together better than many of the others, Hershel included. The boy who rose up was the short-haired blond who seemed perfectly at ease. It was as though he had

been sitting in air conditioning all day; not even his hair was too ruffled. Hershel didn't know what his ability was, but in this situation it was an awesome boon. It was humorous to see the two standing next to each other, Chad with his height and broad shoulders next to Mary's slim frame and understated smile. If someone was looking in from the outside, they would have never guessed what those two had in common.

"Okay class, I want you to take a good look at these two. Before, they were just names, but now you've seen their faces. These are the two freshmen standing at the top of the heap. They are the number one ranks from both sexes, and I have to tell you, there is a large gap between them and the rest of you. So burn these faces into your minds, because from now until the end of the year your only real goal is to beat them. You have one year to get stronger, get faster, get better, and take another shot at the combat trials. In the world of Heroes if you aren't the strongest, you're just next in line to die. Work hard," Coach George said. He dismissed Mary and Chad to go sit down then took a step back as Coach Persephone came to the front.

"I want to speak briefly with you about the year to come," Coach Persephone said. "For the first semester we will be spending all three hours as we have today, only with gradually increasing intensity. This is done to give you the base endurance and strength that every Hero needs to function. After winter break, however, the format will change. We will still be spending the first two hours with physical training, but afterward we will be splitting you into two classes. They will be combat training and alternative training."

There was a murmur among the students. What kind of training was there besides combat? Coach Persephone ignored the commotion and went straight to answering the implied question.

"Alternative training is where we will help those of you with skills ill-suited to fighting learn to use them effectively in the field. Though some of you will no doubt think that this is inferior to combat training, let me assure you that there are ways to protect the innocent for those of us who can't throw a tank."

She paused for a moment and Hershel thought he saw her dart a glance at Coach George. But as she resumed a moment later he assured himself it must have been imaginary.

"As for who will go in what class, the top five ranked students from each sex will automatically be in combat training, while the bottom five will automatically be in alternative training. The rest of you will be evaluated by Coach George and me to determine where your talents lie," Coach

Persephone explained.

A hand went up shockingly fast. Hershel recognized the question asker as Sasha from his morning misadventure.

“Yes, Ms. Foster?” Coach Persephone said, pointing to Sasha.

“What if we are in the bottom five but really want to do combat training? Is there any way for us to prove we can handle it?”

“Actually, yes,” Coach Persephone said. “You can challenge another student for their rank. The two of you will be assigned a supervisor, a combat room, and a healer on hand. Then you will duke it out, and whoever is standing at the end keeps the higher rank.”

“But why would people with higher ranks agree to a challenge? All they can do is lose,” Sasha pointed out.

“They very well might deny you the right to challenge. Of course, this is a graded class that requires a passing grade to continue with the Hero Certification Program, and you will find nearly all of you lack the physical strength to pass it on merit alone. Fighting in challenges earns you bonus points, and successfully defending your rank earns you significantly more points. On the other hand, declining challenges will take points off of your grade, so sitting pretty on your rank is a dangerous move to make unless you are confident that you’re strong enough to handle every hurdle Coach George and I will put before you,” Coach Persephone said.

Hershel felt his heart sink. He had been certain that the fighting was behind them until the end of the year. Hershel comforted himself by trying to remember that he wouldn’t actually have to fight anyone: Roy was the one with the ranking.

“There are rules for the challenging process, though,” Coach Persephone continued. “The main one is the rule of five. You can only challenge someone within five ranks of you. If you want someone higher, you’ll have to climb your way to them challenge by challenge. Additionally, the top five on either side cannot be challenged by anyone lower. So rank six cannot go after rank five even though they are one rank apart. This is due to the difference in ability that the top five have compared to the rest of the class. They may challenge within their ranks, but otherwise none of you can fight them until the end of the year. Aside from that, make sure all fights are registered and monitored. Otherwise they don’t count, and in fact will be punished severely. Everyone understand?”

The class nodded collectively.

“Good. Now go hit the showers. You all stink to hell. Oh, and enjoy the weekend. It’s the last one you’ll have for months with only minor soreness,” Coach Persephone said.

## 22.

“Mary Smith, daughter of William and Rebecca Smith. Diagnosed with abilities at age two when she was discovered telepathically lifting her blocks. Confirmed to be Powered at age five when training and coaching left her unable to block out others’ thoughts. Several more years of attempts to gain control ended in failure and validated the diagnosis. Left home at the age of ten to live in the woodlands her grandfather had willed her mother. Maintains contact with family when she goes into town for supplies, usually semi-annually,” Mr. Transport read from the top paper stuffed into the manila folder.

“If she still sees her parents shouldn’t she remember her name?” Mr. Numbers pointed out.

“Apparently she never really learned it,” Mr. Transport explained as he flipped through her file. “Since her telepathy was always active she could sense when people’s thoughts were directed at her. The name wasn’t reinforced and eventually the few people who interacted with her lost the habit of using it.”

“That makes sense, I suppose. What it doesn’t do, though, is explain why she can tolerate a range of five miles if she’s been out of civilization for seven years. Her focus should have atrophied, not evolved,” Mr. Numbers said nervously. He rose from the table in the living room of his and Mr. Transport’s apartment and went to the fridge to get a bottle of water.

“I’ve been digging on that,” Mr. Transport replied. “It seems that even in the forest she never got silence. Animals still have thoughts; they’re just more primordial than humans. From the telepaths I’ve talked with, they describe it as hearing a conversation in a foreign language. It might be loud, but because it’s gibberish, it’s easier to ignore. That’s why she was able to live there and hold onto at least some of her sanity.”

“Some of her sanity,” Mr. Numbers mumbled. “For all the pity people keep showing her, the girl seems to be adjusting fine. The bear thing is a bit odd, but otherwise she’s doing as well as the others and better than some.”

“She’s a telepath. She knows what normal people are thinking, so she emulates those thoughts and the actions that follow. Just because she can fake societal adaptation doesn’t mean there aren’t some scars on her from her years as a Powered,” Mr. Transport said.

“Yes, except those scars have turned out to be riverbeds that send her

abilities gushing forth in blasts far beyond what her experience should warrant,” Mr. Numbers said.

“I don’t know about that,” Mr. Transport retorted. “What is experience if not the accumulation of scars and lessons that allow us to use our mind, bodies, and powers more effectively?”

“I’m not getting into a philosophy or semantics argument with you. I’m just laying the facts out on the table. You and I recommended a girl whose experience as a Powered has likely made her one of the strongest, if not *the* strongest, Supers of her generation,” Mr. Numbers said with as much control as he had available at hand. Opening his water he retook his seat and began looking through the files on his side of the table.

“You’re worrying too much,” Mr. Transport said. “The only reason the dean even looked twice at her is because he knew about her past, which is why I lobbied not to divulge that information to staff. Aside from that, we both know she isn’t the strongest. You watched the combat tapes with me and read the files.”

“True,” Mr. Numbers agreed. “I daresay the only reason this hasn’t fallen down on our heads is because compared to that boy even Mary would have one hell of a fight.”

“Exactly. It doesn’t matter if she is near the top; hell, Roy was fifth and Vince was eighth so she has company. The only thing that cannot happen is Mary becoming the undisputed strongest in her grade. It would be troublesome with any of them, really, but with her we would have to own up to the oversight,” Mr. Transport said.

“Who would have ever thought spending all those years without any control would actually *help* her so much?” Mr. Numbers asked with no expectation of an answer.

“It’s my fault,” Mr. Transport said. “I handle research. If I had only looked into telepathic training methods I might have discovered this.”

“It’s no one’s fault or it’s both of our fault. Neither of us goes down alone, you know that,” Mr. Numbers corrected immediately. “Besides which, I think it might be a good thing in the long run.”

“How do you mean?” Mr. Transport asked.

“What would be worse to deal with: a tremendously powerful telepath who can control her abilities or one that has no say whatsoever in what she does?” Mr. Numbers asked.

Mr. Transport was silent for a few moments, imagining each encounter realistically rather than snapping off the obvious acceptable answer. There were several things about Mr. Transport that Mr. Numbers didn't always care for, but his tendency to take each question posed to him with seriousness and analysis was not one of them.

"Well," Mr. Transport said at last. "I think that would depend on the context of dealing with them. If they are on our side, then control is preferable; however, if they've gone rogue, then I'd rather have them lacking any real influence on what their power does."

"A good answer," Mr. Numbers said honestly. "So that means we should worry less about precisely where we might have gone wrong, and focus on ensuring that Mary Smith and every other subject we recommended into the program stays on the straight and narrow path. That's the best way we demonstrate the sound judgment of our selections."

"Very good plan," Mr. Transport commented. "That leaves us with the meat of the matter. How exactly do we do that?"



## 23.

Logically speaking, there had to be a part of Alice that didn't hurt. She comprehended that in a rational, understanding-of-biology sort of way. Unfortunately, all that knowledge couldn't convince her body to find a position that didn't provoke spasms of soreness coursing through her nerves. Never in her life did she suspect she would ever look back on her one-on-one sessions with her personal trainer as such a light, peaceful workout. Yet here she was.

"Here", in this case, was sprawled out on the sofa in the communal area, watching TV and trying desperately to get comfortable. She would have much preferred to be in her own room, or even in just the girls' lobby, but returning home had led to the discovery that the cable had only been hooked up to the common room so far. The other rooms only had access to basic channels, and subpar entertainment wasn't going to do much to take her mind off of what today's workout had done to her.

Unfortunately, the others seemed to have had the same idea, as they were slumped over and groaning in the chairs and loveseats scattered throughout the room. Everyone was there except Hershel, who had excused himself a few minutes ago to change. Alice couldn't really imagine he owned more comfortable clothing than the sweat pants and Star Wars t-shirt he had been wearing, but she supposed anything was possible. The rest of them were watching a sitcom, shifting occasionally and presumably trying not to think about how they had an entire week of this starting on Monday. Even Mary's presence didn't take the top spot of worry in Alice's mind for the moment. The only thought that telepath was going to pick up from her was: "Ow. Ouch. Ugh. Why did I sign up for this?"

Alice's forced focus on the flat-screen was interrupted by a bottle of water bumping gently against her head.

"What the hell!" Alice exclaimed. She relaxed as she noticed the bottle was not alone. It seemed to have come with an assortment of friends who were hovering a few inches from the faces of Vince and Nick. Mary was already sipping on hers. Alice may have been weary, but she wasn't so tired she couldn't put this simple puzzle together.

"Oh. Thank you for the water, Mary," Alice said as she took the bottle and twisted off the cap.

"No trouble," Mary replied honestly. It wasn't as though the bottles

were heavy or hard to maneuver. The four weary would-be warriors sat in suffering silence after that, the only punctuation aside from groans and television banter being the occasional sip from a bottle of water.

“Well, well, you ladies sure can’t handle your exercise,” said a deep voice from the side of the room. Standing in the doorway to the boys’ side, wearing a different shirt and jeans but sporting the same cowboy hat, stood the man from the karaoke platform last night. For a moment, Alice thought she had certainly slipped off to sleep in her fugue of pain and gladly welcomed the dream that was beginning. That delusion was quickly shattered by Vince.

“Who are you and how did you get in here?” Vince cried, pulling himself halfway from his chair. It would have been a grander gesture if he had made it all the way out, but given his current physical condition it was still somewhat impressive.

“Now come on, Vince, is that anyway to talk to the man whose mess you cleaned up this morning?” the tall man asked, waltzing over to the chair Hershel had been sitting in and plopping down forcefully. Alice had no idea what he was talking about, but now that she knew it wasn’t a dream she was beginning to feel concern gnaw at her. She had been privy to the designs of this place. There should be no way he could have come in through the boys’ side. The only entrance was the front one. So how had this cowboy broken into their home?

“Roy?” Vince asked skeptically.

“Sure as shit in an outhouse,” Roy replied. “Pleasure to finally meet you in the flesh.” Roy leaned over from his chair and grasped Vince’s hand, giving it a hearty shake.

“Hey, that’s cool that you guys know each other,” Nick said. “Maybe now you explain why there’s a stranger sitting in our home. Who else thinks that would be awesome? Just me? Come on, show of hands, people.” Nick threw up his own hand and Mary followed suit.

“Um,” Vince began awkwardly. “This is Roy. He’s Hershel... kind of.”

“How can he be Hershel?” Alice asked incredulously.

“Well, you see, my beautiful blonde cohabitant, I’m the form the fatty turns into when he can’t take it anymore,” Roy explained. “Not only does he get stronger, faster, leaner, and all around sexier, but he also gets a pair of testicles and a shot of social sense.”

“So when Hershel said he was going to change earlier...” Alice let her thought die out as she put the pieces together.

“Tubbo was hurting, and he doesn’t cope so well with pain, especially from a workout obviously, so he went to his room and invited me to handle things. I don’t suffer from shit like pain or fatigue,” Roy said as he flashed a set of pearly-white teeth around the room.

“Stop calling him fat,” Vince said. “It isn’t nice. Hershel is our friend, and he’s just a little out of shape.”

“An action figure in the microwave is a little out of shape,” Roy said. “Hershel is a doughy chickenshit. Besides, I can talk all the trash I damn well please. I *am* Hershel, after all.”

“No, you aren’t,” Vince disagreed. “Hershel might be awkward but at least he has always been kind to everyone. You’re not.”

“It might not be a fun truth, but that doesn’t take make it not real. Just deal with it, Freak Hair, me and Husky are the same person,” Roy said.

“No, you’re not!” Vince said, his voice rising noticeably.

“Yes, I am,” Roy reinforced.

“Yes, he is,” Mary said softly. Both of the battling boys looked at her. She was sitting in her chair, petting No on his head and not meeting either of their eyes. There was something about her that seemed... sad. Just a few moments ago she had been the same old Mary with the wild hair and the unreadable eyes. But now, in the time that Roy had come in the room, it was like some of the light had left her somehow. It was impossible to put a finger on what was different, but it was equally impossible to ignore the change.

“Well,” Roy said after a pause. “If the telepath agrees with me, it must be true. I’ll see you girls later on.” Roy’s eyes stared right at Vince and Nick, making certain they knew he wasn’t just referring to the actual women.

“Where are you going?” Vince asked, an undisguised tint of suspicion in his voice.

“Whiskey Shallows,” Roy replied. “It’s a popular club around here. I told a few of the admirers I met last night that I’d stop by. You girls are welcome to come, if you think you can peel yourself out of your chairs.” With that, Roy tipped his hat to Mary and Alice, and then strode out the front door.

“Wasn’t he just a ray of sunshine?” Nick quipped. Alice chuckled politely, but Mary just stayed quiet while Vince seemed to be rolling

something around in his head. Slowly, but forcefully, Vince uprooted himself from his sitting position and got on his feet.

“I’m going with him,” Vince said simply.

“The word ‘why’ comes to mind,” Nick said. “Are you in the mood for more narcissism and ego?”

“Not even remotely,” Vince replied. “But I was there this morning when Hershel had to try and explain himself out of the situation Roy had left him in. The worst part of it wasn’t watching him run, or panic, or take that girl’s insults and accusations in stride. It was how resolved he was to it. Like he had done this countless times before and expected to be doing it for a long time after.”

“What do you think you can do?” Alice asked.

“Not sure,” Vince replied. “Maybe I can at least keep tabs on Roy, and help Hershel with whatever mess he wakes up in.”

“I’m sure Hershel is used to dealing with these things alone,” Alice said, a trace of bitterness clinging to her words.

“I’m sure he is. But Hershel doesn’t have to be alone anymore. I want to go show him that,” Vince said.

“Very noble,” Nick said sarcastically. “I expect you’ll expect us to rally to your words and leap up to join the cause?”

“No. I expect you all to do what you need to do. I’m sure some of you need to rest. I need to do this,” Vince countered. “I’m changing clothes and leaving in twenty minutes. If you want to come, then come. If not, then I’ll see you in the morning.”

It was an idiotic idea. They were all sore and tired, and it was evident that Vince was on a fool’s errand. Roy was three ranks higher, so even if Vince wanted to, he wouldn’t be able to do anything to stop him. There was literally no point to anything that silver-haired moron was doing. So why did Alice... care?

## 24.

“Well,” Nick said at a volume higher than normal. “This seems like a lovely, cultured establishment.”

Vince, Alice, and Nick all stood in the entryway of Whiskey Shallows, a club with a country theme and a powerfully pumping stereo system. It had taken Vince a few minutes to look up the address and he cursed himself for having wasted the time. They could have found their way using the tacky neon glow and the ridiculously loud music, both of which were detectable from blocks away. He was happy Nick and Alice had decided to join him, though. Nick he was only moderately surprised by; after all, his sandy-haired friend did seem to enjoy getting out of the dorm at any chance presented. Alice, on the other hand, had been a huge surprise when she emerged from her room in fashionable top and tailored blue jeans.

It had been a very fortunate surprise, though, because in the haste of his bravado Vince had utterly forgotten that he didn't own a car. Neither did Nick, since before the procedure they had a tendency to blow up around him, so it fell on Alice to cram the two boys into her BMW and chauffeur them to the club. Vince had been very tempted to ask why she was tagging along but decided against it. It wasn't as though she had been unfriendly at all; he had merely thought she would see herself above coming to a place like this. It was his own fault for making such assumptions about her just because she projected a confident and put-together aura.

As the out-of-place trio maneuvered through the robust crowd, Vince was surprised by how many people his age seemed to be in attendance. Most of them had large black Xs on their hands like he and his friends, so they were old enough to get in but too young to drink. He looked around more and realized that none of the faces looked familiar. It made more sense, though: only the Supers would be reeling after today's workout. The rest of the college would be out celebrating their return to school and the first Friday of the year. This place was close to campus, so even if the younger students couldn't drink, it was still a good place to get off campus and meet new people.

Vince passed a pair of girls in a corner taking shots behind a potted plant while trying to keep their hands out of sight. He re-evaluated the possible reasons the underage students would come. Vince was tempted to yell at Nick and Alice to split up and cover more ground looking for Roy, but he wasn't confident he would hear or feel the cell phone in his pocket with all the bass and noise surrounding them.

That was a shame, because he could have used a way to cover more ground. The club was huge, with three bars on the first floor and two more on the second. An enormous dance floor sat a few inches higher on the first floor, making sure everyone could have a good view of the people shaking their stuff. It seemed oddly like a way to window shop to Vince. After a moment, he realized that's exactly what it was.

"I think we're doing this wrong!" Alice yelled, getting Vince and Nick's attention and dragging them near a set of restrooms where things were marginally quieter.

"How so?" Vince asked.

"We're looking for one person in a giant club. That could take forever. We should be looking for a group instead," Alice explained.

"Why a group? All we want is Roy," Vince pointed out.

"Yes, but Roy said he was meeting people here," Alice explained.

"If he was telling the truth," Vince said.

"Yeah, if we're going to question his truthfulness to us then we have to ask ourselves if we're even at the right club. So why don't we just work under the assumption he was honest for now?" Nick said.

"Right. So, if Roy is meeting people, then we need to look for a cluster of people, probably ones that are our age if he met them that night on campus," Alice said.

"Cluster of people our age," Vince agreed. He turned his head back toward the club and tried to count how many clusters of people he saw in the college-aged range. Once he passed thirty, he turned back around to Alice. "I don't suppose there's anything else that would narrow it down?"

"It'll be almost, if not completely, made up of girls," Alice replied.

"How do you know that?" Nick asked.

"I saw him last night. Trust me, that boy only has one thing on his mind and definitely isn't just sitting on a stool all night," Alice said.

"Gotcha," Vince said quickly, closing off the subject. "Okay, let's scout for groups of girls our age with a cowboy hat poking out from the middle."

"You know, I'm a little surprised there's such a massive country bar out here," Nick said as they started back into the main area of the club.

“There’s everything around Lander. There’s a gay club, a techno club, a dance club, and a bunch of bars,” Alice said. “Lander is a pretty huge school and people come from all over America, so local business owners found a niche for just about every kind of way to drink and meet new copulation partners.”

Nick laughed loudly. “I’ve never heard picking up bar skanks put in such a classy way.”

“It’s a gift,” Alice replied.

“Speaking of gifts, I think we just got handed one,” Vince said, pointing to the dance floor. Standing a few yards away from them, dancing simultaneously with three girls, was Roy. He was moving smoothly to the beat while holding a drink in his left hand. Periodically he would take sips, usually while executing spin maneuvers. Not one drop of the brown liquid was spilled; in fact, none of it looked like it dared summon up the nerve to even approach the rim of the glass, unless, of course, it was making a direct beeline for Roy’s mouth.

Vince noticed Roy’s hands weren’t stamped and wondered how he managed to pull that off. It wasn’t really relevant, so he pushed the thought aside. What mattered now was keeping an eye on Roy, and, if possible, dissuading him from abandoning Hershel in an awkward situation. If Roy wasn’t willing to play along, at least Vince might be able to explain things to the girl so she didn’t freak out whenever Roy changed back. He didn’t have much of a plan, but then Vince had never been great at strategy. He set a goal and he found a way. That style had always worked out before, so he set his shoulders and prepared to shadow Roy for the rest of the night.

That plan was almost immediately interrupted by a familiar voice behind him.

“Hello again, Sucker Punch.”

## 25.

Vince turned around and found himself face to face with his former opponent.

“Michael, right?” Vince asked.

“Damn right,” Michael replied. Michael was a touch out of place, wardrobe-wise, having chosen to wear only a black tank top that drew attention to the impressive arms and shoulders his practice at boxing had wrought him. Combined with the steel-toed boots on his feet and the unpleasant sneer on his face, it made for an appearance that was anything but warm or friendly.

“You decided to come out tonight too, I guess,” Vince said.

“We did indeed,” Michael corrected him. A quick glance behind Michael revealed two other males standing in proximity to him. One was tall with ink-black hair and the other was strikingly familiar. It only took Vince a moment to place him; after all, Coach George had been adamant about searing that face into his mind.

“You’re Chad, aren’t you?” Vince asked. Nick jerked visibly and Alice suddenly seemed uncomfortable. From the rumors that were floating around, Chad had dominated every opponent he went up against except the number two rank. Even then it hadn’t really been a close fight: just a minute or so longer than the others.

“I am,” Chad confirmed. “You’re Vince Reynolds, the girl to your side is Alice Adair, and the boy slowly edging his way behind you is Nicholas Campbell.”

“Wow,” Vince said. “That’s really impressive. How’d you do that?”

“Student directory and an eidetic memory,” Chad replied with a bored shrug.

“Awesome; well, it was cool running into you, Michael, but we’re sort of in the middle of something,” Vince said as he delicately tried to extricate his group from Michael’s and go back to keeping an eye on Roy.

“Hold up there, Silver,” Michael said, placing a hand firmly on Vince’s shoulder. “I owe you some payback for the cheap shot you pulled on me the other day.”



“You mean where I used my talent against yours in a perfectly acceptable and legal way during a recorded and observed fight? Is that how you define a cheap shot?” Vince asked.

“You lured me in thinking you couldn’t do anything but run, then you cracked me in the jaw. You tricked me,” Michael said, his hand tightening its grip.

“It’s called strategy, and I suggest you adapt to it quickly in this school. Isn’t this moot anyway, though? You won, you beat me, you proved you’re the better fighter between us,” Vince tried to pacify him.

“Maybe I feel like I deserve a little more payback for that crack across the jaw,” Michael replied, flexing his impressive arms.

“Okay,” Vince said simply. In a motion like flowing mercury, Vince snagged Michael’s arm carelessly exposed arm, gripped his shoulder, and applied pressure above and below the elbow. “If that’s the case, then maybe you should keep in mind that I’m a better than you when we take out any extraordinary advantages.”

“Gaah,” Michael grunted as Vince intensified the pressure. He was holding Michael close so that anyone that happened to glance over might think they were still merely talking. He had come here to observe Roy under the radar; the last thing he needed was the bouncers noticing what was going on.

“I’m going to have to ask you to release him,” Chad said as he moved slowly up to Michael’s side. “As you recall, those beneath the top five ranks may not challenge us formally or otherwise.”

“Wasn’t really looking for a challenge, I just wanted to come out with my friends. Michael here is the one who had a problem with mutual coexistence,” Vince replied.

“Noted, but you’re the one who took it from verbal to physical,” Chad countered. “It was a nice grab, by the way, but from the way his face is contorting, I’d say you have only a few more seconds to release it before Michael makes this situation worse and escalates things.”

Vince looked at Chad, and then felt the shaking in Michael’s muscles. If it had been anything else Vince might have been able to absorb Michael’s energy and keep him restrained. With cold, though, that just wasn’t an option. Making a snap decision, Vince released his hold and quickly took a step back.

Michael wheeled around, eyes wide and a long vein bulging

noticeably on the top of this head. He shook off the arm that Vince had been holding and then curled the hand into a fist.

"If you do this, you know there will be severe consequences, right?" Chad asked in his same detached tone.

"Fuck 'em," Michael replied tersely. Vince shifted his footing slightly, readying himself to dodge Michael's blows.

"You girls take all the fun out of being at a club, you know that?" The voice was Roy, who swaggered up to the tense zone that surrounded Vince and Michael. "I mean, really, you were doing good at staying covert for a while, but taking a fighting stance? Now everybody is paying attention to you shitheads instead of me."

"Not your fight," Michael grunted, his eyes never wavering from Vince's waiting form.

"No, but it is my night. So now instead of drinking and playing with my girls, I had to take time out of it to come make sure you morons don't go trashing the club," Roy countered.

"I don't need your help, Roy," Vince said as he measured Michael's breathing and line of sight.

"I didn't come to help you. I came to help me. Now both of you calm your asses down so I can have fun or I'll take you out back make sure neither of you can so much as move, let alone fight," Roy said calmly.

"I'm ranked higher than you, dipshit," Michael spat at him.

"Well then, here are two things to think about. First, you never fought me, so that ranking is arbitrary. Second, Hershel is the one on the admittance slip, so he's the one who can't be uncovered as a Super. As far as any regulations are concerned, I'm nothing more than a public persona," Roy said, a big grin spreading across his face as he took a sip of his drink.

"Hold on," Nick said, jumping in from the sidelines. "You're saying that you could tear this club down around us and they couldn't touch Hershel for exposing his identity?"

"You're a touch smarter than those glasses make you look," Roy answered. "So, girls, what do we do? Do you both of you walk away right now, or do I beat you both like red-headed stepchildren?"

"I don't need to fight," Vince said honestly.

Michael's response took a touch longer. His eyes lingered on Vince a while longer, then glanced at Roy, and finally took in all of the people who were casting sidelong glances at him in the area around them. Vince was better than him without abilities, and if he used them, he'd be exposed. He took a long breath and lowered his arms.

"Another time, Vince," Michael said, before turning and walking back in the direction of the entrance. The tall dark-haired boy accompanied him. Chad, however, lingered for a moment.

"Nice job, Roy," Chad said. "It would have been problematic to deal with the fallout from that. And as for you, Mr. Reynolds, it would be wise to remember your place at this school."

"What's that supposed to mean?" Vince asked, his voice still a hair on edge from the almost-confrontation.

"It means you are weak. You have no rights to things such as pride and aggression when dealing with those more powerful than you. You would be better served to bow your head and avoid conflict," Chad explained.

"That's not really my strong point," Vince shot back.

"If it were, I wouldn't have needed to tell you that, now would I? Think about it, because the next time Michael catches up to you, he will likely be smart enough to do it without a crowd present," Chad said. He turned and moved to catch up with the other two, sliding easily through the crowd at an oddly brisk speed.

"What a cock," Roy said simply. "Anyway, that was fun, but time to go tell my prospects of the night about how I stopped a bar fight. Later, bitches."

"Wait," Vince said. "Um... thank you. For keeping Michael and me out of trouble."

"Don't thank me," Roy said in a more serious tone than he had shown all night. "I wasn't lying; I only came over because your little show was distracting my girls. If it hadn't had a direct impact on me, I would have watched him beat you right off your high horse and never lifted a finger. We share a dorm, but we're not friends. Remember that." Roy turned away from them and began heading back to the dance floor.

"I don't know about you two," Nick said as Roy walked further from them. "But personally, I'm seriously beginning to think that he might not be the best candidates for our bff for life club. Just me talking out loud, though;

totally open to other opinions.”

“Shut up, Nick,” Vince and Alice said in unison.

## 26.

“Good afternoon, class; I trust everyone had a fun weekend,” Dean Blaine said he breezed into the classroom. It was Tuesday and all of the freshmen were gathered in his lecture hall for their first real session of Ethics of Heroism. Well, almost all of them. As Nick did his customary sweep of the room, he noticed three of the seats now stood out as empty. There had been two students in Monday’s gym who had broken down crying and one who had simply collapsed. As he stared at the cheap plastic chairs left vacant, the fact that there was no possibility these two things weren’t related gnawed at the back of his mind.

In fact, what were the odds that this lecture hall would have had precisely the correct number of seats for this class size? Nick realized these empty seats were meant to be noticed, meant to remind them that some of the class hadn’t been able to cut it. And if they were using a method like this, then it could only mean they expected many more chairs to be ownerless before the year was through.

“Now then, I’m sure some of you are wondering how we will be discussing such a complicated and tangled topic as ethics and how it pertains to Supers. We’re going to start by defining who Supers are. And that, my students, begins with an understanding of where they come from. Can anyone tell me who the first officially-documented Super is, and in what year they revealed themselves?”

Several hands shot up, and Dean Blaine pointed to a boy in the front. “Mr. Desoto, please enlighten us.”

“The first documented Super was Captain Starlight, a former World War Two pilot who approached the government about working with people like him, the so-called extraordinary individuals that would eventually be known as Supers. This took place in 1957, and was caused by Captain Starlight’s frustration with returning to civilian life after having achieved a sense of purpose defending his country during the war,” the boy in front said. Nick realized with a start that it was the other guy they had dealt with on Friday, Shane Desoto. His voice hadn’t sounded familiar; but then again, Shane hadn’t spoken once the entire night.

“You’re close, Shane. Speculations about motivations aside, it was indeed Captain Starlight who approached the government, but that took place in 1959,” Dean Blaine corrected.

“Actually, the government officially announced that the meeting took place then, but it really happened two years prior. It took two years of testing, trials, and Captain Starlight bringing in other Supers for them to see before the politicians were able to accept that there were such things as Supers. They changed the date because they felt taking two years to confirm things that could plainly be read as incompetence to the voters,” Shane corrected right back.

“An interesting hypothesis,” Dean Blaine said. “May I ask where you heard this theory?”

“My grandfather told me,” Shane replied.

“Wise as I’m sure your grandfather is, I’d wager he wasn’t necessarily privy to every detail of Captain Starlight’s life and rise to fame,” Dean Blaine said.

“Would you, now?” Shane said simply, crossing his arms.

“Thank you, Shane, let’s move on. Now, can anyone tell me what important events came about as a result of Captain Starlight’s revelation to the government?” Dena Blaine asked. This time he pointed at a hand in the air that was familiar to Nick.

“Because of Captain Starlight’s brave actions revealing the existence of Supers, the government made the rest of the country aware of them, setting up special laws to protect aspects of their lives, and ultimately set up the Hero Certification Program so that Supers who had undergone proper training and qualification would be able to protect our country without being held liable for incidental damages caused in the process,” Alice said rapidly.

“Very nice, Ms. Adair,” Dean Blaine complimented. “Those are all correct, though there were of course many more ramifications to Captain Starlight’s revelation than that; but we will get into those at a later date. For now, we know that Captain Starlight is the first officially documented Super. Does that mean he was the first in existence? Please tell us, Mr. Campbell.”

“No,” Nick responded immediately. The dean had been spamming his eyes across the class during the discussion thus far. Nick had noticed those eyes hesitate for an instant on him seconds before the question came, so he had been ready for it. Nick noted that he needed to look just a dash more interested in discussions. The goal was to draw no attention, neither from being too observant nor too apathetic. Clearly he had fumbled and fallen below the acceptable apathy line.

“How do you know that?” Dean Blaine continued pressing.

“I don’t,” Nick said honestly. “But nobody does. Since there are no records, we can’t really say for certain one way or the other if Captain Starlight was the first Super. The popular consensus leans toward the negative, though.”

“Correct, Mr. Campbell. Without documentation, no one can prove or disprove the existence of previous Supers,” Dean Blaine said. “Of course, the odds of an entire genetic offshoot beginning with one man and then continuing to appear at a steady rate for half a century afterwards are ludicrously low. This means that most likely Captain Starlight was nowhere near the first. Again, though, we don’t know, and this lack of knowledge has led to many controversies and theories. Who can name one?”

Dean Blaine pointed to a young man wearing glasses in the front row.

“My mom used to say that the stories of the Greek gods were really about Supers, the people just didn’t know it then.”

“A popular theory indeed,” Dean Blaine said. “And this led to one of the greatest controversies that our existence has caused in this century. Who would like to venture a guess on what that was? Mr. Reynolds, give it a go.”

“Religion,” Vince said awkwardly. It was an interesting paradox that Vince could be so self-assured and insecure simultaneously. Nick already had a few ideas at how that tendency could work in his own favor, though.

“Please elaborate,” Dean Blaine told him.

“People pretty much all agreed that the Greek gods were just Supers in disguise, so it was only a matter of time until they began speculating about whether other iconic figures from the past had really just been people with powers. The most obvious ones were all those tied to magical events. Prophets, saviors, warriors of their lord, everything was thrown into even more speculation that it had been,” Vince explained.

“Very good, Mr. Reynolds,” Dean Blaine said. “The addition of Supers to our world meant the opening of new possibilities. Events that had been mentioned in religious texts could now be challenged not only on historical accuracy, but also the possibility that even if they had occurred, then perhaps it wasn’t a divine hand that had guided them. Now the truly devout had to defend their faith on a whole other level, and it was not well-received. Now then: we know who the first Super was, can anyone tell me the name of the first documented Powered?”

“Who cares?” yelled out the braided blonde from the back. The rest of class laughed and echoed sentiment.

“I’d wager the Poweredreds care,” Dean Blaine said seriously.

“Yeah, but they don’t count. I mean, this is a class about heroism and Supers, not malfunctioning humans. Why would we need to know anything about the first of a thousand gears to break?” the girl shot back.

“You wouldn’t,” Dean Blaine said. “Unless you were the one trying to put the machine those gears had supported back together. I want you to think about that, because Poweredreds will be coming up over the course of this class. Their history and ours are more closely intertwined that you all might realize. Still, since no one seems to be informed enough to discuss their origins today, we can skip ahead to how Captain Starlight helped create special criminal classifications for Supers gone awry.”

Nick cursed under his breath. Dean Blaine’s eyes had hesitated on him again when he mentioned Poweredreds. Of course the dean of the college would know about him and the others, but little tics like that would give them away if anyone ever suspected. Nick took a deep breath. No one had any reason to think they were any different from every other Super in attendance. He just had to keep it that way.



## 27.

Roy was acclimating well to gym. After the first day of trying, Hershel had wimped out and left the physical exertion up to his bigger, stronger, better half. Hershel handled the ethics class, and then made the change before even setting foot in front of the coaches, all of which suited Roy just fine. Hershel got to sit through the boring stuff while Roy was free to show all these pansies what a real Super could do.

Roy lapped the majority of the freshman boys once again as he breezed past them on the track. While every day was sprinkled with different exercises, running was a constant. It seemed that whatever curriculum Coach George had in mind factored heavily on cardio and endurance. For most of the class it was a grueling daily struggle just to keep up and not give in. For Roy, and a few other notable adversaries, it was a time to get in a light jog and simmer in the envy of others. On that note, Roy noticed Vince giving him a dirty look as he breezed by. Vince had been cold to him since that night in the club. It probably hadn't helped matters that Roy had shaken his dorm mates off and left Hershel alone to wake up in a downtown alleyway. Normally he and his fat body-based roommate shared a more cordial relationship, but Roy had felt the need to make a point.

A little fallout from a cohabitant didn't even qualify as a blip on Roy's radar. The idiot in sunglasses had been just as chatty since that night, and of course Alice was practically drooling every time he walked in a room, so that made Vince the only one with an open grudge against him. It was possible Mary didn't like him either, but she seemed to always avoid him so who could tell? Besides, that one was off limits. He could push Fatty around a lot, but slipping the sausage to a chick he liked would be like declaring open war. Roy felt that would cut into a lot of his time and fun, so it was easier to give the chubby dipshit a little bit of accommodation.

"Time!" Coach George yelled from across the gym. "Line up!"

The boys and girls filtered from their opposite sides of the track to the center of the gym where George and Persephone stood waiting. The rule of staying on opposite sides had stayed in effect since day one, and though lapping was permitted, falling behind was never tolerated. So far every student who had fallen back into the other sex's group had been taken out and not seen again. It seemed they were playing hardball. Roy was almost entertained.

"Well," Coach George said once they had all fallen into line. "It seems

you survived another day. I'm a touch surprised; I was sure we'd be kicking another couple of you out today."

Panicked looks fleetingly leapt across the faces of some of the slower students. Personally, Roy felt it was warranted. Even Fatty had kept up with his group for one day. If he could do it then the only excuse for failing was laziness.

"I was wrong," Coach George continued. "If I were you, I'd savor those words, because you won't be hearing them very often. I'm a man, though, and I'll own up to my mistakes. I was wrong, and today every one of you managed to keep up and stay in the program. So the question I find myself asking is this: are you all just much that better than I thought, or are you all so weak and worthless that it's impossible to tell which piece of shit has sunk to the bottom of the toilet?"

No one said anything, the weaker students struck dumb with fear and the stronger ones arrogantly self-assured that this conversation wasn't for them.

"I think it might be the latter," Coach George said. "So I want you all to think about something. There are only so many spots for advancement out of this year into the next. Just passing isn't enough; we're only taking the best. Next time you're slowing down to stay with your group instead of driving harder to leave them behind and knock some slow shit out of the running, I want you to think about that. Think real hard about whether you want to be a nice guy who helps everyone squeak by with mediocrity or if you want to be a Hero. Because I promise you, a mediocre Hero is just a corpse that's a week behind schedule. Get out of my sight."

The line broke and students began moving quickly toward the showers. Roy began swaggering but felt a firm hand grip him on the shoulder.

"Daniels," Coach George said. "I think you and I need to talk for a minute."

"Sure, Coach," Roy said with his patented smile flashing. "Want me to run faster and drive a few more people out of the running?"

"Actually, Daniels, I'd like you to take note of something," Coach George said.

"What's that?" Roy asked.

"In this class there are several students with physical gifts well-suited to endurance or running. Yet you lap the other groups more times than anyone

else,” Coach George explained. “Why do you think that is?”

“I guess I just want it more,” Roy replied, chuckling at his own wit.

“Try again, jackass. It’s because everyone else is taking this time and training seriously. Ms. Foster alone could have passed everyone several thousand times during that run. But she didn’t because she was running without using her abilities as much as possible,” Coach George said.

“Sounds pretty dumb to me,” Roy replied. “I mean, if she’s that good at running, then why practice it so much?”

“Because she wants to get stronger. As does Mr. Taylor, who shares your limitless endurance yet maintained a constant pace during today’s run,” Coach George said without an inkling of a smile in his eyes.

“You just told everyone to work harder in order to knock each other out, now you’re getting on my ass for doing well and applauding others for sandbagging it,” Roy said, shaking Coach George’s hand loose. The gym had emptied entirely by this point, only the two of them left in its large interior.

“I’m ‘getting on your ass’ because you accomplished nothing today, or yesterday, or really any day except the one you came in human form. This is training, Daniels, it’s designed to make you stronger, better, and more able to endure the toll that being a Hero will put on you. This is the foundation of being a Hero, and you’re pissing it away,” Coach George said.

“Thanks for the lecture,” Roy shot back. “But in case you forgot, I’m in the top five of this ‘hard-working class’ and I would have been number one if I hadn’t fought that stupid psychic guy.”

“No, you wouldn’t have,” Coach George said simply. “You’re the weakest of the strong, Daniels, and if you don’t start putting in the effort, you won’t even hold onto that title for more than a year.”

“Okay, how am I supposed to, then? I don’t get tired, I don’t get sore, I don’t even get short of breath,” Roy countered. “I’m super strong, super durable, and have super endurance. Now please tell me how to get any benefit out of lifting a few weights and jogging around a track.”

“Sorry, Daniels,” Coach George said with a shake of his head. “That’s not my job. Heroes are supposed to be creative and show ingenuity. If I were you, I’d get cracking on that, before the rest of the class leaves you behind.”

Roy scoffed. “It hasn’t even been a week yet.”

“Time flies, Daniels,” Coach George said as he turned and headed

toward the exit. “And at this level, so will the progress of your competition.”

## 28.

As the days turned into weeks, Vince noticed a funny thing. He was getting used to his new life at Lander. He was slowly growing accustomed to sleeping in the same bed under the same roof every night. He was growing tolerant of Nick's flapping gums and Roy's douchebag demeanor. His body was even beginning to get used to the five-times-a-week workouts from hell. It was strange, but each day that passed found him more comfortable with his life here. He was beginning to feel like he might finally have a shred of normalcy in life, with his powers under control and his wandering suspended. On the day he truly became certain of this, he reached an important decision.

"Sasha, would you like to go out with me tonight?" Vince asked stiffly. It wasn't that he wasn't comfortable around his speedy friend, but the life he'd had before Lander had hardly equipped him with much experience in the realm of a social life. This deficiency was one of the reasons he was determined to stop dallying and make up for lost time.

"Sure," Sasha replied offhandedly. The two were eating breakfast on this Friday morning as was their routine, so she sipped her orange juice before continuing. "I think Julia is going out tonight and the other two never stay in on a Friday, so we can hang out and watch a movie."

"Yes... well, that does sound fun," Vince fumbled. "But... you see, I meant would you join me tonight... in a romantic capacity. As in a date."

"Yeah, I know," Sasha said. "Took you long enough. Why do you think I invited you to come watch a movie in my empty dorm?"

"Oh," Vince said. Then realization dawned. "Oooh. I was thinking something a bit more traditional for our first date."

"You got a car?" Sasha interrupted.

"Um... no," Vince admitted.

"Me neither, and while I can get anywhere in town in under ten seconds, it sort of takes the fun out if you can't join me," Sasha pointed out. "So our options are a romantic candlelit dinner in the dining hall or watching a movie."

"How's seven work for you?" Vince asked.

"Better make it seven thirty. We do still have to grab a shitty dinner

here after all,” Sasha said.

“Point well made,” Vince agreed.

\* \* \*

“I still can’t believe you finally grew a pair,” Nick commented as he reclined on the boys’ lounge couch and flipped through the television stations.

“I always had a pair,” Vince said defensively. “I was just getting settled in to my new surroundings. What do you think?”

“You look dumb,” Nick replied, barely glancing at Vince’s outfit.

“How is a button-down shirt and slacks considered dumb?” Vince asked.

“It’s not, if you’re going on a job interview. For going to a dorm to watch a movie, though... little dumb,” Nick replied.

“I think it looks nice,” Hershel chimed in softly.

Vince stood in the lounge area with his open door to his back. Nick and Hershel were sitting on the couch, killing time and offering him advice on what outfit to wear. In Vince’s room loomed an ever-rising stack of rejected combinations. In all the years Vince was a wanderer he had never needed to worry about fashion. After thirty minutes of trying on clothes, he was beginning to suspect that he should have relished that time a touch more than he had.

“No, Nick’s right,” Vince said. “This is too formal. I’ll try again.” Vince turned around and went back into his room, shutting the door while he changed.

“Nick,” Hershel said shyly. “Not that I don’t appreciate him wanting our input, but why isn’t he asking the girls what he should wear on a date? You know, since it’s a girl he’s trying to impress after all.”

“Because, my dear boy, he’s an idiot. Plus I may have convinced him I’m something of a fashion expert,” Nick said, not quite hiding the chuckle in his voice.

“That’s mean! You shouldn’t trick him like that; he seems to really be into this girl,” Hershel said.

Nick cocked an eyebrow and stared at Hershel. Of course, as far as Hershel could tell, Nick had simply put his eyebrow up and pointed his sunglasses right at him, but the general effect was still the same. Sort of. “I

don't remember saying I tricked him at any point in that statement."

"So... wait... you really are a fashion expert?" Hershel asked, confused.

"I feel like my wardrobe answers that question all on its own," Nick replied. At that moment Nick was wearing carpenter's pants and a green tank top. Not knowing what to say, Hershel did the next best thing. He changed the subject.

"If you have time tonight, do me a favor," Hershel said. "When you see Roy, please tell him he has to stop skipping gym. He's missed three classes already in the past few weeks and we only get four per semester. I don't want to get drummed out just because my alter ego is throwing a hissy fit."

"He has seemed a bit more on edge," Nick agreed. "I mean, even when he comes to class he always looks a bit pissed. That first week he was pretty cheerful when he was lapping us in typical asshole form. What happened?"

Hershel let out a sigh. "Coach George called him out on not trying and told him if he doesn't work harder the other Supers will leave him behind."

"And he felt the appropriate response was to change nothing except his consistent attendance?" Nick asked.

"He doesn't like it when people imply there might be others stronger than he is, and he handles it like a child," Hershel said. "I think he wants George to admit he was wrong and that Roy could skip the whole semester and still come out on top."

"Could he?" Nick asked, a slight twinge of true curiosity creeping into his voice.

"Maybe," Hershel said. "The only person who's ever been able to beat him was our dad, so I know it can be done, but other than that no one has ever really gotten the better of him in a fight."

"What about during the opening combat trials? I mean, if he came in fifth he must have lost to someone," Nick pointed out.

"He lost to rank number four, Rich Weaver. Rich has the ability to trap your mind in a fantasy, leaving you utterly unable to move or even perceive what's happening around you. He locked Roy down in the first five seconds, then just walked out of the room. Twenty minutes later they declared him the

winner and he let Roy free,” Hershel explained.

Nick let out a whistle. “Hard to believe someone that powerful only made it to rank four.”

“Apparently he fought Chad after that,” Hershel noted.

“That does explain a bit of it,” Nick agreed. “I have got to find out what that guy’s ability is.” Nick’s speculations were interrupted by the sound of Vince’s door opening again.

“Okay, this had better be good because if I don’t leave soon I’m going to be late!” Vince declared as he stepped out of his room.

Nick looked him carefully up and down this time. Vince was wearing black jeans and a pair of flip flops, along with a blue collared shirt. The dark tones worked well with his hair, yet didn’t clash noticeably with the striking blue of his eyes. Vince had accidentally assembled a truly well-planned outfit that highlighted the best parts of himself.

“Adequate,” Nick said simply.

“I’ll take it,” Vince said with a smile, shutting his room door and dashing out the exit.

“Ahh, young love,” Nick said to no one in particular.

“I should probably go change, too,” Hershel said, pulling himself up from the chair.

“Big plans tonight?” Nick asked.

“Not that I know of,” Hershel replied. “But I can feel Roy stirring around in my head and he’s pretty anxious to get going. I guess he’s got something planned.”

“Cool,” Nick said. “You two have fun.”

“Will do,” Hershel assured.

Roy did indeed have something big planned, and at that moment it was unfortunate that Hershel only had access to Roy’s thoughts from when he was out. Hershel couldn’t see any of the things going on in Roy’s consciousness when Roy was nothing more than a presence in the brain. If Hershel had been able to, though, he undoubtedly would have refused to change and thwarted Roy’s scheme before it even began.

That, however, was not the case.





## 29.

Vince arrived at Sasha's dorm and paused before knocking. He checked his breath, made sure his clothes were fitting well, and ran his fingers through his silver hair. Vince was nervous, almost pathetically so. It wasn't that he had never had any romantic interaction with a lady; but a real date, possibly the beginning of a real relationship? That was something he'd always considered impossible until the procedure. Vince took a deep breath to steady himself. Sasha liked him, obviously, and they'd been getting to know each other for weeks since the semester began. It was never going to be any easier than this.

Vince finally pulled back his hand and knocked on Sasha's door.

"Took you long enough," Sasha said as she pulled the door open. "Come on in, I've popcorn in the microwave."

"You look nice," Vince said sheepishly and he stepped into her room.

"You, too," Sasha said with a smile. "So who helped dress you?"

\* \* \*

"Yeah, baby, I'll meet you by the Science building and then we can head on back to your place," Roy said into his phone as he stepped in the Melbrook common room. He snapped his cell shut and surveyed the area. No one was around; it seemed even the losers he was bunking with had things to do on a Friday night. Roy had half expected to run into Nick when he left his room, but the sunglass-wearing fashion boy had left the area while Roy was busy changing. Alice was a pretty little dish; not surprising she would have places to be. As for Mary... well, who knew what telepaths did for fun? The only other member of Melbrook missing was Vince, and Roy knew very well where that dick was.

Roy Daniels was many things: lover, fighter, drinker, warrior. One of the many things Roy didn't consider himself, though, was the type of man who let someone else interfere in his business. Vince had spearheaded that little campaign to follow him around the club and try to cockblock, and now that he had a date, Roy was finally going to be able to return the favor. The key difference was, of course, that Roy wasn't going to *try* anything. Roy was going to *do*, and succeed, because Roy was a winner. And that's how the world worked for winners.

Adjusting his hat, Roy strode through the common room, down the

hall, and stepped out into the brisk night air. He paused to admire the stars in the sky, thinking he might try fucking a broad outside tonight to savor nature's beauty. About that time was he felt a tremendous force smash across the back of his head and hoist him into the air.

\* \* \*

"Is ninja a type of power?" Vince asked as the black-clad warrior on the screen leapt into the air, hovered, and dropped down, depositing his fist in some unwitting minion's fragile skull. "I mean, sticking someone with the title of ninja seems to convey all kinds of ridiculous abilities. I almost wonder if there's a real world variation of this somewhere."

"Plenty of people have enhanced physical abilities," Sasha pointed out. "So I suppose doing a couple of these moves would be possible for a chunk of the Super population. I don't think that's so much the point of these films, though. It's about learning a martial art and training yourself into being above normal."

"I guess you're right," Vince agreed.

"Personally, I think it's almost sad. All those normal people out there, desperate for any avenue to make themselves extraordinary. I see why so many people follow that path," Sasha commented as she munched on popcorn.

"What about people who learn martial arts for exercise, or self-defense, or to gain a better control over their bodies and their minds? I don't think everyone who learns a martial art is trying to somehow become one of us," Vince countered.

Sasha shrugged. "People can say whatever they want about their reasons, it doesn't make it the truth. I developed at an early age, so I have almost no memories of not being a Super, and let me tell you something. No matter how nice someone is, no matter how respectful they are, no matter they say, every powerless human you meet is thinking the same thing when they meet you."

"And what's that?" Vince asked.

"They're thinking: 'Why not me?' They think they should have been born special, been made powerful, been gifted," Sasha said. "I might just be a cynic, but it's what I believe. And I'd bet dollars to donuts that any telepath would back me up."

"I could always ask Mary," Vince said.

“You should, I bet she’d have some interesting input on it,” Sasha said.

“Maybe,” Vince said. “I doubt I will though. She’s sort of quiet and doesn’t hang around us too much. I think she might just like keeping to herself, and I don’t want to interfere with that too much.”

\* \* \*

Roy began kicking and punching as soon he felt himself hoisted. He wasn’t sure who the dumbass with the big balls and the death wish was, but he was going to pound into their head what a stupid fucking idea jumping Roy Daniels had been.

“That won’t do any good,” said a small voice from behind him.

Roy kicked a few more times, but the voice was right. He wasn’t hitting anyone or anything, just flailing about in air. Slowly he let his limbs relax and felt his body rotate around until he was looking at the source of the small voice.

“You know, if you wanted me that bad you should have just bought me a bottle of whiskey,” Roy spat out.

“It’s almost cute how you default to your enormous ego when you don’t know what to do,” said Mary, leaning relaxed against the outer wall of the dorm, effortlessly holding Roy ten feet above the ground.

“So if you didn’t want to flirt, why’d you sucker punch me?” Roy asked.

“The blast was to distract you while I put you in the air,” Mary explained. “You’ve a very strong person, but this situation renders you essentially powerless.”

“Oh yeah?” Roy let a wild grin slide across his face, then began flexing and kicking with all his might. He twisted his hips, slammed his fists together, and jerked his body in every conceivable direction to rip himself free of her grip.

“Yes, actually,” Mary said with a smile of her own. Roy’s wild tantrum had moved him not one iota closer to the ground or away from his starting position. “I’m holding you by the torso in midair. You have no ground to push off against, so no way to generate significant force. Hercules himself wouldn’t be able to break free of me once he was suspended.”

Roy’s motions slowly subsided. “I totally thought that would work.”

“You watch too many movies,” Mary chided him. “Do yourself a favor, pick up a physics book. Even you’ll find a little use in it.”

“Noted,” Roy said. “So why are you hanging me up here like laundry anyway?”

“We need to talk,” Mary replied.

“We can’t talk on the ground?” Roy asked.

“We could, but both of us know that would be me talking and you not listening. I like this situation better,” Mary said.

Roy automatically started to lie and tell her of course he would be listening when she talked to him, but then his brain kicked in and he remembered what type of Super he was talking to. “Okay, fine,” Roy said instead. “I would have ignored you. Now, what’s so damn important you needed to shanghai me?”

“A couple of things,” Mary said, walking slowly around Roy. He noticed that he was being turned as she moved, so that they were always face to face. “First off, I’m not letting you ruin Vince’s date tonight.”

“Oh, it wouldn’t have been ruined,” Roy tried to explain.

“You planned on barging in with Julia and having loud, raucous sex in her and Sasha’s room to ruin any romance their date might have held,” Mary said.

“Right... but that doesn’t mean it would have worked,” Roy said.

“What it would have done is piss Vince off, especially when he realized that you knew about the date because he told Hershel. That would cause him to pull back from dealing with your other persona, robbing Hershel of one of the very few friends he has here,” Mary elaborated.

“Yeah, well, Fatty can always stick to his usual friends, pie and fried chicken,” Roy snapped.

He might have said more, but he was too busy suddenly being violently shaken like a soda in a paint mixer. “That,” Mary said in a much more strained voice, “is the other thing you and I are going to talk about.”

\* \* \*

“Do you ever shut up?” Sasha asked.

“Huh?” Vince squawked, caught unaware.

“Seriously, the movie has gone to the end credits, we’re sitting here in a barely lit room with only a few inches between us, and you are still trying to talk about plot validity,” Sasha said.

“I’m... sorry,” Vince said. “I haven’t really been on a lot of dates.”

“Surely you jest,” Sasha said. “It’s okay, I knew you were a noob when I met you. Might even be why I kind of like you.”

“Kind of like me, eh?” Vince said with a slowly-spreading smile, barely visible in the television’s fading glow.

“A little, but it’s diminishing the more you talk,” Sasha replied.

“Gotcha,” Vince said. He leaned forward and wrapped his arms around Sasha, pulling her close to him. His lips quickly sought hers and found them with only minimal searching. The kiss was awkward at first, but as the intensity grew both lost their sense of self consciousness and became immersed in the task at hand. When they finally parted to take a breath, it was Sasha whose words filled the electrified silence.

“Not bad for a virgin,” she mused.

“Stop talking so much,” Vince shot back. She did, and they sank down onto the couch, movie, popcorn, and the rest of the world soon utterly forgotten.

\* \* \*

“You’re going to stop talking badly about Hershel, you’re going to stop making it a point of being a raging dick to his friends, and most importantly of all, you’re going to start going to every one of your classes and actually try to get stronger,” Mary said as she slowly twirled Roy around.

“That’s an awful lot of demands for a girl with no leverage,” Roy replied.

Mary snorted out a small laugh. “Sorry, it’s just funny because in this situation, you’re the one with no leverage. And I mean that in a literal sense, not the slang kind. Never mind; Hershel will get it tomorrow.”

“Nice to know Tubbo is good for something,” Roy said.

“You think I’m kidding, don’t you?” Mary asked. “Or that you can play along and once you’re on the ground never listen to me again. You don’t even perceive me as a threat, despite the fact that I’ve rendered you helpless.”

“Truth be told, I see this more as a Mexican standoff,” Roy said. “I

can't hurt you, but you can't really hurt me, either. All you can do is inconvenience me. Thing is, me not being able to hurt you is only applicable right now. Once I'm set down, that limitation is no longer in place."

"A Mexican standoff is when both parties are able to kill each other, not unable to hurt one another," Mary pointed out.

"You know a lot of slang for a wilderness dweller," Roy commented.

"I'm a telepath; we learn things quickly," Mary said. She stopped turning Roy and began walking toward him. "In fact, I've learned so many things about my roommates they aren't to be believed. Take you, for example; I learned something very interesting about you." Mary stopped just short of Roy, only a few inches out of his reach. Then she took three steps forward. He began to coil and leap for her, but her next words froze him in his tracks.

"I know you have a weakness, invulnerable cowboy."

Roy was very, very still. "Okay, so I'm only resistant to damage, not invulnerable to it. No one is truly invulnerable. Supers might be able to shrug off a lot but there are always limits. That doesn't make it a weakness."

Mary shook her head. "That's not what I'm talking about and you know it. I've already gotten the phone number. I'll use it."

They stared at each other in silence for a few moments, thoughts racing through Roy's head and Mary calmly observing them.

"What do you want?" Roy asked at last.

"I already told you," Mary said. "Be nice to Hershel's friends, don't be mean to Hershel, and start showing up and working in class."

"I can do the first two, but the last is out of my hands," Roy explained. "I'm beyond human limits in physical power. What the fuck is running around a gym going to do for me?"

"You know, I think this might be my fault," Mary said. "I'm trying to force you into something without giving you motivation. I apologize."

Roy felt himself lowering and his feet hit the ground. He and Mary were now only inches apart. It was well within his ability to crush her like a grape. Yet staring into those amber eyes, Roy felt something he wasn't accustomed to: a sense of hesitation. This girl had been ready for him entirely. He would be a damn fool to assume she didn't have some sort of ace in the hole if he made a move. Aside from the one she had already alluded to.

“I’m going to offer you a deal,” Mary said.

“Listening,” Roy shot back, then thought back to their conversation. “I mean, really listening this time.”

“So you do learn,” Mary quipped. “Here is my proposition. Go challenge Chad tomorrow for his ranked spot. You’re in the top five as well, so it should be allowed. If you can take that spot, then you can forget all of my other demands and I promise to neither use nor divulge what I know about your weakness.”

“Pssh, is that it? Shit, I was planning on beating him up for that spot soon anyway. All that does is make my Saturday fun. So what’s the catch?” Roy asked.

“The catch is that if you lose, you have to do all the things I asked of you, without back talk or me constantly threatening you. Essentially, if you lose, I own your ass until the end of the year,” Mary explained.

“That’s it?” Roy tried to confirm.

“That’s it.” Mary nodded.

“Deal,” Roy said. “I’ll do it around one, so make sure you don’t miss the show tomorrow.” Roy began striding off toward the west of campus.

“Oh, Roy,” Mary called out.

“Yeah?” Roy asked without turning his head.

“You haven’t won your freedom yet, so if you ruin Vince’s date, you do know I’ll bring hell crashing down upon you, right?” Mary asked.

Roy nodded briskly, then, as casually as he could possibly manage, changed his direction toward the north of campus where his car was parked.

\* \* \*

Julia stood outside the Science building, pink heels and low-cut shirt giving away that her plans for the night involved the attentions of a male. She checked her watch for the tenth time that minute and muttered under her breath.

“Where the fuck is Roy?”



## 30.

Alice was bored... again. As she sauntered into the dorm lobby, laden with bags and well-lit by the morning sun, she began to entertain the possibility that the reason she was bored might be because she was lonely. Yesterday had left her feeling restless, so she'd jumped in her car, taken a firm grip on Daddy's credit cards, and burned up the town. Her dinner had been at an upscale restaurant that none of the rest of her class would even be able to pronounce, let alone gain entrance to. She'd even spent the night in a posh hotel room rather than trudge back across town to her comparatively squalid little dorm room. She had spoiled and pampered herself rotten to lift her ever-falling spirits.

And yet... and yet she still felt off somehow. It couldn't be loneliness, not logically. Alice had always been alone. Certainly Daddy had kept a devoted staff at the house, but they had never been people to her, let alone friends. Daddy's schedule had always kept him busy, and her mother had passed away when Alice was just a girl, so she had grown up entertaining herself.

Of course, her play had to be within limits, lest she grow too joyful and lift off the ground. It was a hard lesson Alice had learned at a very early age: joy that lets you walk on air is always followed by the misery of crashing to the ground. It was why Alice had learned to grow so careful in her emotions, so reserved in her feelings. Being alone all the time had actually been a boon there; she had suffered through fewer stimuli and gained a greater sense of control.

She walked into the girls' side of the dorm, then into her room where she deposited her bags. Perhaps it was loneliness after all, only it was affecting her for the first time because her nose was constantly being shoved in it. All around the other students were meeting people and forging friendships. Yet Alice, for all her social grace and tact, had spent yet another Friday night by herself. Well, it wasn't as though she'd ever had to make friends before. She could always manage a conversation with surgical precision, but when it came to taking that leap, she found herself unable to plunge. She realized it was a somewhat ironic way to think of her dilemma, given that her own ability left her nothing to fear from gravity, though since that was only a recent development perhaps it make a sad sort of sense.

Alice began putting her new purchases into her closet. Maybe she would try reaching out to her dorm mates tonight. It was Saturday, after all; one had to assume they were planning something. They were idiots, and of

course Mary was an enormous hazard, but they knew what it had been like to grow up as a Powered, and that should provide them with at least a bit of common ground.

Besides, if she spent too many more Friday nights alone she'd have to hire a contractor to widen her closet.

\* \* \*

"They don't seem to be bonding well," Mr. Numbers noted as he and Mr. Transport dined on breakfast in their apartment.

"Is that problematic to our plan?" Mr. Transport inquired.

"Not problematic per se; however, it does lower our chances of success," Mr. Numbers replied.

"Do tell," Mr. Transport encouraged.

"We need to keep them on the straight and narrow. Peer pressure is a tool that could work for or against us in the long run, but it is not even on our thin list of options until they are moving and thinking as some semblance of a collective," Mr. Numbers explained.

Mr. Transport took a bite of eggs and mulled over Mr. Numbers' point. "So you're proposing that it would be easier for us to manage them as a herd than as individuals."

"Correct," Mr. Numbers confirmed. "It does put all of our eggs in one basket; however, given that the loss of even one student to the side of villainy will result in our termination, it could be said that all the eggs are in that basket anyway."

"I see what you mean," Mr. Transport agreed. "Do you have a solution?"

"Not a solution, but a possibility. One of the greatest ways to bind people together is through necessity," Mr. Numbers said.

"Ah, such as how you and I didn't care for each other when we were first paired, yet trusting our lives to one another forged a powerful bond," Mr. Transport commented.

"Precisely," Mr. Numbers said.

"We can't put their lives in constant danger without arousing suspicion, though," Mr. Transport pointed out. "What do they value with similar or equal intensity?"

“Their grades,” Mr. Numbers replied succinctly.

With that, the conversational portion of breakfast was done.

\* \* \*

Hershel’s eyes snapped open and he leapt out of bed. He couldn’t believe the memories Roy had bequeathed him from last night. Fighting the number one rank? And Mary... he was both floored and amazed by her. To handle Roy with such total control... it was unreal. She’d even exploited his weakness for betting. Fortunately, Hershel had no such weakness, nor did he have any desire to see his alter ego be singled out as the top rank. Roy was already unbearable lately; winning this fight would validate his arrogance and leave him unwilling to listen to another word from anyone. Hershel threw on some pants and a wrinkled shirt. He was getting off campus, walking to a coffee shop, and keeping Roy caged all day long.

“No, you’re not,” said a familiar voice as he stepped into the common room. Mary was waiting for him, sitting on a couch facing the boys’ side and sipping on a bottle of water.

“I most certainly am,” Hershel replied with more force than he meant to. “Do you have any idea what you did? Once Roy beats Chad there won’t even be the possibility of getting through to him. You should have just hung the weakness over his head if you wanted to stop him.”

Mary shook her head. “Roy would never have obeyed, no matter what it cost him. You and I both know that. The only real chance of controlling Roy is through his own pride. He made a bet on his own strength. He’ll honor it when he loses.”

“When he loses?” Hershel said, stepping toward Mary and sitting down on the couch. “Do you know who you’re talking about? I’ve barely seen any Super even damage Roy. The only person who ever beat him in combat was our dad, and he’s the one who taught Roy how to fight. He won’t lose, Mary. He never loses, on anything or to anyone.”

“That’s why I told him to fight Chad,” Mary explained. “Roy needs to be beaten. He needs a dose of humility, and you need to stop thinking of him as this unstoppable force. You’re just as strong as he is, and after today’s fight I hope you’ll be one step closer to believing that.”

Hershel paused. His initial fear and hesitation was waning as the girl he had been unable to stop thinking about was finally talking to him and looking at him. A part of him wanted to believe she was right and that Roy could lose. The only hurdle was the decade of experience that said otherwise.

Still, as he looked into her strong amber eyes, his resolve weakened, and he did what men have been doing for women they admired for centuries.

He caved.

“You really think Chad might be able to beat him?” Hershel asked.

“I know he can,” Mary responded. “Unlike the rest of you, I’ve actually seen Chad fight.”

Hershel snorted. “You know Roy will remember this whole conversation when he comes out.”

“Will it change his mind?”

Hershel shook his head. “Roy could hear a direct message from God saying he’d lose and still show up ready to go.”

“Exactly,” Mary said. “So have breakfast and relax for a bit, then go change into Roy. Let this day run its course and have a little faith.”

“I’ll try,” Hershel said. “Why are you so sure Roy will lose, though?”

“For one thing, he already fought a number one ranked student last night, and you saw how well he did there,” Mary countered.

“You didn’t hurt him though,” Hershel pointed out.

“See if you still say that to me tonight,” Mary said.

## 31.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport were interrupted from washing their breakfast dishes by the sound of the intercom from the kitchen sounding.

“Mary and Roy here. Roy would like to be taken down to the underground levels for some special training,” came Mary’s voice through the speakers. “Would Mr. Transport be on hand to assist us?”

Mr. Number and Mr. Transport looked at each and gave a nod. Mr. Transport went to the door and swung it open.

“Good morning, students,” Mr. Transport declared. “So, you wish to put in some training time on the weekend? Well, kudos for the determination.”

“Actually,” Roy said from just outside of the door frame, beyond where Mr. Numbers could see at his vantage point. “I’m the only one going down, and I’d appreciate it if you hung close by. I don’t think my business down there will take too long.”

“You can always take the lift back up if you like,” Mr. Transport tried to deflect.

“Please go with him,” said Mary. “I think it will prove to be necessary.”

“Very well,” Mr. Transport said with a sigh. “Let’s keep it brisk if at all possible, though. I do have things to do today.”

“No problem,” Mary assured him. “Roy will be done in no time at all, won’t you, Roy?”

“Damn straight,” Roy agreed.

“Well then, off we go,” said Mr. Transport. A moment later the door began to swing shut, as Mr. Transport’s body was no longer there to wedge it open. It stopped before locking, pushed open by the small hand of Mary Smith, who poked her head into the room and locked eyes with Mr. Numbers.

“While they’re gone, what do you say to a game of chess?” Mary asked.

“Hardly seems like much of a game with a telepath,” Mr. Numbers replied gruffly.

“No powers, I promise,” Mary countered with a quick grin.

“...Fine,” Mr. Numbers conceded. The girl was clearly up to something, and if he wanted to know what it was, he needed more data.

\* \* \*

“So, what exercise are you looking to practice?” Mr. Transport asked Roy as they arrived in the underground area.

“Combat,” Roy replied briskly, striding off toward the gym. Mr. Transport had never seen Roy so focused on anything. He was in his combat uniform, had left his silly little hat back above ground, and seemed to be dead set on whatever he was doing. It was more progress than Mr. Transport had dared hope to see from the narcissist in the entirety of the year, let alone in the span of a few days.

Mr. Transport set off at a brisk stride, not quite catching up to Roy but never losing sight of him, either. They emerged in the weight room, where several grey uniforms were getting some exercise and a pair of black uniforms stood at the back near the free weights. It seemed the two other freshmen were stretching near the weights rather than lifting them. Mr. Transport was about to conclude they must be too intimidated by the older students to work out around them when he suddenly realized who those two students were.

“Chad!” Roy bellowed from across the room, drawing the attention of everyone there, included the intended party, Chad Taylor, who was stretching in the rear of the room. “I’ve come to challenge you for your rank of number one,” Roy declared, cocky smirk twitching at the edges of his mouth.

Chad seemed oddly nonplussed, giving Roy a shrug then turning to the other freshman. “Shane,” Chad said to his friend, “would you be so kind as to get a referee and a healer so that we may count this as a sanctioned match?”

The other freshman, Shane one could easily conclude, gave a nod of his head and set off toward the offices. Chad finished his stretches and walked calmly over to Roy.

“You’re in the top five, so I won’t be taking it as easy on you,” Chad said simply.

“Taking it easy? You’re better off worrying how you’ll find the strength to last five minutes against the powerhouse you’re facing,” Roy shot back.

“So be it,” Chad replied. “Let’s select a room.”

\* \* \*

“First move goes to the lady,” Mr. Numbers said as he gazed at the chessboard.

“Let me guess: from my opening move you can deduce my strategy, my personality type, and my favorite food?” Mary asked.

“I thought you promised no powers.”

“I didn’t need my powers to know that about you,” Mary answered, moving a pawn forward. Before her finger had even left the piece Mr. Numbers had run the simulations and knew how he would win this game.

Mr. Numbers made his move, then Mary, and so on for several turns. Eventually Mr. Numbers made a striking observation.

“You have no idea how to play chess, do you?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“I don’t know much about strategy,” Mary admitted. “I do know how the pieces move, though.”

“Are you sure? Because your moves say otherwise. The only ones you’re using to their full potential are the pawns and the king,” Mr. Numbers pointed out.

“Sometimes a piece must make some bad moves in order to make good ones,” Mary said.

“I presume you have an explanation to go with that statement. By all means proceed.”

“All right,” Mary said, picking up a piece. “Take this rook for example. It’s quite the powerhouse when you think about it: unstoppable, yet limited in its movements. All it can do is charge blindly forward or to the side.”

“Correct,” Mr. Numbers said.

“But what if this rook were defective somehow? What if it could only move forward, if it didn’t have the ability to go side to side? That weakness would limit its movements tremendously, leaving the rest of my army vulnerable and exposed.”

“That is true, but only in a purely academic sense. A rook is used by the player wielding it, so it cannot be defective. Your rook can move side to

side, and is not broken, so start using it correctly,” Mr. Numbers retorted.

“Let’s say that it was,” Mary continued. “Just for the sake of argument. Now, as the person controlling this army, should my first priority be charging blindly forward despite my weakness, or would it be fixing my rook?”

Mr. Numbers said nothing for a moment, then moved his knight and took another of Mary’s pawns.

“You know an oddly large amount about human psychology for a girl who has lived in the woods,” Mr. Numbers observed.

“Maybe,” Mary acquiesced. “But have you ever wondered what I did out there in the silence?”

“Ate gophers?”

“Actually yes, but that’s not what I meant,” Mary said. “I spent those years growing up, and sorting through all the thoughts and things I’d been exposed to. I read psychology books and watched television, all to put the various and often horrible things I had grown up hearing leak from people’s minds into perspective. Think of it as intensive training in dealing with humanity.”

“An interesting pastime,” Mr. Numbers said. “Also, checkmate.”

“Good game,” Mary said with a smile. “We should play again next weekend. Maybe I’ll learn a little about strategy from battling you.”

“I don’t think you’ll improve that much playing only one game a week,” Mr. Numbers told her.

“Probably not, but at least by next week my rook should be in working order.”

\* \* \*

“This is a match for ranking,” said the crackling pre-recorded voice of Dean Blaine through the speaker box. “As such, the only ways to win are to incapacitate your opponent or force him to give up. Should serious injury occur, the match will be stopped while the injury is reviewed and it is determined if the student can continue. Everyone do your best!”

The last line felt a touch out of place as Roy and Chad stared at each other from across their combat cell. The referee was watching from his post through the thickened window, along with Mr. Transport, a girl in grey who



was presumably a healer, and Shane. For Roy, though, none of those people mattered. The only one of consequence was looking unconcerned and removing the jacket from his uniform, revealing a tank top scarcely hiding the chiseled physique underneath it. Chad let his arms dangle at his sides, then gave the referee the nod that he was ready. Roy followed suit, and a husky male voice bellowed through the speaker.

“Begin!”

Roy took off charging. There was no need to draw this out: he was going to crush this blond pansy and take that number one rank as soon as possible. In a way he felt a touch of gratitude to Mary. If she hadn’t given him the idea, he might have forgotten all about the rankings in lieu of the fine tail that was wandering the campus. This was good, though. He’d win the fight, show everyone he was the best, and let Coach George know he could shove that smug concern right up his ass.

Roy didn’t even slow down as he neared Chad, rearing back and clocking him with a right hook that would knock a train off course.

At least, that was what he’d planned to do.

Roy’s fist whistled powerfully through the air, connecting with nothing and jerking Roy slightly off balance. Before he could recover, an open palm crashed into his jaw, sending him stumbling back and leaving stars in his eyes.

“Fuck,” Roy swore. That had hurt. It had been a long time since anything had hurt, which meant that Chad wasn’t all apathy and confidence. That kid had to be swinging with some significant power to make Roy feel his blows.

“This is pointless,” Chad said, seemingly unmoved from the position he’d been in when Roy charged him. That was impossible, though; Roy knew he’d been dead on with his punch. Unless Chad had an ability that let them pass through him. “I’m sorry, but you aren’t strong enough for me to waste time fighting. I won’t learn anything from beating you.”

“Giving up already?” Roy asked as he drew himself to his feet.

“Walk away, Mr. Daniels,” Chad said. “You’ve stepped into a league you’re not ready for.”

“Fuck you I’m not!” Roy yelled, swinging his huge fists for Chad’s midsection as he rushed forward once more. Roy missed again, but this time he saw what happened. Chad wasn’t teleporting or going insubstantial: he

simply avoided the blows by a fraction of an inch, gauging the punches perfectly and placing his body in the areas where they were not. Another palm struck Roy's ear and he felt his vision blur for a moment.

"You are a mess. You telegraph your movements so clearly that anyone with a bit of training can read them. You swing wild, focusing on power instead of precision, and you have literally no guard nor reflexes designed to block. You fight like what you are: an overly-strong fool who never learned how to focus his power," Chad said as Roy blinked and cleared his eyes.

"I don't need to guard from sissy shit like that," Roy spat back. "Or didn't you know? I'm tougher than a three dollar steak, Blondie."

"Spoken like a true idiot," Chad sighed. "I'll bet you didn't even bother to research my power before challenging me, did you?"

"Yeah, I know what it is," Roy responded. "You suck dick like a Hoover."

"I'm afraid not. My power is total control of my body, from the muscles that I move all the way down to my cells and the chemical composition of my skin," Chad explained.

"That's a pretty weak-ass power," Roy chuckled.

Chad's eyes narrowed slightly. "Most people would agree. Of course, most people wouldn't think of ingesting carbon and other minerals daily to make their muscles as strong as interwoven steel cables and their bones harder than diamonds. Most people underestimate how useful full control of one's mind is, of the power in being able to instantly train reflexes and increase the speed of one's perception. I assure you, it is not a weak power, and if you come at me one more time, I'll illustrate that to you personally."

Roy pulled himself up and blinked one last time to clear his eyes. "Bring it on, babycakes." Roy charged forward once more, but this time didn't get a chance to swing his fists. Roy had barely realized it when Chad was suddenly beneath him, driving his own fist into Roy's stomach. Before the pain could fully register, Chad had taken Roy's left arm and spun it around behind him, cracking and breaking the arm loudly. Roy's feet went out from under him as Chad's hand wrapped around Roy's head and drove it crashing into the concrete. The snap of a kick was all the warning he had before he felt impact and the sensation of broken ribs. In what seemed like less than a second, Chad had utterly destroyed him.

"One last thing about my 'weak' power," Chad hissed down at Roy.

“It is an inheritance from my father.” Chad raised his leg until his foot was over his shoulder, then brought it crashing down on Roy’s head.

## 32.

“I must admit, I did not see this coming,” Mr. Transport remarked.

“I did, eventually,” Mr. Numbers admitted. “Though this is far sooner than I expected.”

The duo was standing outside of the recovery ward where Roy was asleep. Mr. Transport had gone and fetched Mr. Numbers while Roy was being tended to by the healer on duty. Thanks to Roy’s natural toughness and swift healing, he would be fine. Truthfully, this was, to someone with his power, the equivalent of stubbing a toe. It hurt badly when it happened, but there was relatively little actual damage done. The only concern anyone had was a fear that he would revert back to Hershel before the wounds could be treated fully.

“So Mary coaxed him into it somehow,” Mr. Transport said in curiosity. Mr. Numbers had filled in Mr. Transport on the game of chess they had played during Roy’s fight and the conversation that had occurred within it.

“It would appear that way,” Mr. Numbers confirmed. “In all fairness, Roy is hardly the most difficult member of our dormitory to manipulate.”

“Agreed,” Mr. Transport said. “Still, she did an excellent job of tearing down his pride. She talked him into fighting one of the few students in the class who could utterly trounce him.”

Mr. Numbers nodded his agreement. “Roy would never accept his loss in the ranking matches as a genuine failure on his part, since his opponent used mental abilities and dealt no actual damage to him. This time, though... this time he lost on his home turf, in the area where he was certain he reigned supreme.”

“I imagine there is another stage to this plan,” Mr. Transport speculated.

“Certainly,” Mr. Numbers confirmed. “But it’s time for us to start moving proactively on our own. Contact the dean and humbly request to put our new idea into action. Much as I may dislike the way she did it, Mary was correct in what she told me. Right now we’re dealing with pieces that don’t yet see their full potential; they’re reined in by their own perceived limitations.”

“How do we help them with those?” Mr. Transport asked.

“For now we delegate and see how the telepath does at handling it. If she proves unable, we will step in as needed. Our concern is not to help them with their personal demons right now; it’s to get them to start looking at each other as a team, or at least as mutual assets,” Mr. Numbers answered. “We need them to have a group mentality, and the sooner we achieve that, the more effective it will be.”

“You’re right,” Mr. Transport agreed. “I do wonder if this incident will sow any dissent in the group, though. After all, Mary did essentially trick one of the team into being mercilessly beaten.”

“Yes, but it was the member no one liked,” Mr. Numbers pointed out. “How this is perceived by the group depends on her actions and their effects from this point on. Hopefully she has a good plan in place.”

\* \* \*

“I feel achy,” Hershel said as he stirred in one of the oh-so-very uncomfortable recovery room beds.

“Roy was beaten pretty severely,” Mary said from her vigilant perch on a stool next to the bed. She had never left Roy’s side since he was brought here, and when he shifted back into Hershel she had stayed by his side as well.

“I remember,” Hershel said, pulling himself up to a sitting position. “That last kick was a doozy.”

“Yes indeed,” Mary agreed. “They removed all the physical damage, though. What you’re feeling now is essentially residual impulses from the nerves that know there should be pain and recovery in a certain area, even though there isn’t.”

“Hey, I’m not complaining,” Hershel said quickly. “Compared to what he did to Roy, this is some pretty minor soreness.”

“Yes... well... I’m sorry about that,” Mary said slowly. “I knew it would be rough, but it was the only way.”

Hershel leaned forward a bit, wishing he was the sort of person who was confident enough to rest a hand on her shoulder when trying to assure her. “None of that. You gave both Roy and me ample warning about what would happen. Roy was too stubborn to listen, and this is what I was hoping for. I mean, he was pretty groggy at the end, but I could already feel the hammer blow to his pride from that fight. Plus, he lost the bet. You did the right thing.”

“I know,” Mary said with a small nod of the head. “That doesn’t always make it the easy thing though. I hate seeing people get hurt.”

“Well then, let’s make sure it wasn’t in vain,” Hershel replied. “I assume you have some sort of plan now that Roy has to listen to you?”

“Oh yes, indeed I do,” Mary said, a small grin tugging at the corner of her mouth. “Roy will remember this conversation, correct?”

“Yup; we share memories of when the other is in control,” Hershel confirmed.

“Good,” Mary said. “Then listen well, you arrogant moron, because as of now you belong to me. So let’s go over just what you’ll be doing for the rest of the year.”

Even though Hershel knew she was no longer speaking directly to him, the tone of her voice and the glint in her eye compelled him to gulp. Later on, when Roy woke up and remembered the conversation, he would reflect that for once he and Hershel were in agreement.

### 33.

"Welcome, class. If you would take your seats quickly; today we have much to cover," Dean Blaine said as the students filed into Tuesday's Ethics of Heroism class. Nick moved briskly, taking his seat and sliding into his usual defensive posture. It said that he was bored, but not so much so that he wasn't paying attention. It conveyed respect without conveying interest, and all in all served the purpose of making him blend into the sea of faces. Nick might have been considered lacking by some in the power department, but the skills he did possess were honed and polished.

Sitting comfortably in his cocoon of apathetic camouflage, Nick allowed his eyes to wander around the room. He hadn't seen much of his dorm mates this weekend, but then again, he'd spent a lot of time working on a business model for one of his real life classes. Of course he had heard about Roy's sounding defeat at Chad's hands - that one had spread like wildfire - but he hadn't had a chance to catch up on the nitty-gritty details with Hershel. As for Vince, he hadn't come home until Sunday night, and despite Nick's respectable arsenal of wheedling techniques had refused to divulge any details of his weekend. Not that Nick couldn't string things together on his own, but it was always so much more satisfying to coax a secret from someone's lips.

"Class," Dean Blaine said once everyone was sitting in their chairs. "Today I introduce you to what will ultimately culminate in the grade for your mid-term exam." Nick could actually hear necks pop as they swiveled forward in a sudden burst of attention. "You will all be participating in research projects, and in one month you will make a presentation to the class as well as turning in a twenty-page paper."

"I thought we weren't going to have papers in this class?" The speaker was the girl with tightly pulled back braids, or Stella Hawkins as Nick had learned since the first day of class. In all the weeks since then, she had never raised her hand once when asking a question, driving Alice to grind her teeth but not even denting Dean Blaine's plastered-on grin.

Well, that was usually the case at any rate. Today Stella's question triggered a slight twitch in Dean Blaine's right cheek. Nick was confident no one else would have noticed it, but to him it was plain as day. That meant he wasn't as sure-footed on the topic of this project, or that there was something about it that made him uncomfortable. It wasn't much, and Nick wasn't sure what to do with it, but it was something and something didn't mean nothing. Nick trained his complete attention on the now-speaking dean.

"That is usually the case," Dean Blaine replied, no trace of the tremor from his face audible in his voice. "However, this is something of a special project. It will be a team project, one to help you all branch out and better get to know your fellow classmates. It will be on the full career of a Hero from the list I'll be hanging on the board. I want you to trace them from their training, their career path, and their retirement. Yes, Miss Adair?"

Alice's hand had been up since halfway through the dean's explanation, and it seemed she was a few seconds short of waving it around like an elementary school student to demand his attention. "How is this applicable from an ethics standpoint? This seems more like a history project."

"As I was explaining before you put your hand up," Dean Blaine replied curtly, "this project will trace the life of a famous Hero. While I do want you to spend some time discussing the major events in their life, the real purpose of this project is to look over some of their exploits from a more personal level. Look at some of the foes they dealt with and some of the battles they lost. Your goal is to help me, and the rest of your class, understand the motivations and complications of the person behind the mask."

"How does that help us with ethics?" Stella belted from the back of the room once more.

"Think of it as advanced preparation. I want you to see what these people went through, because a Hero's life is often fraught with hard choices and living with the consequences of them. By digging deep and understanding choices that past Heroes have made, I hope you will ask yourself what decisions you would have made in similar circumstances," Dean Blaine explained. "Because one day, those life and death decisions could be on your shoulders, and it is best to start preparing for them sooner rather than later."

Dean Blaine braced himself for more questions as his explanation finished, but the somber subject matter seemed to have cowed even Stella. It wasn't surprising; after all, when one thought about becoming a Hero, one usually focused on the glory and pride that came with defending the innocent. Rarely did people stop and consider the responsibility that came along with the job when deciding the direction into which to punch a villain could result in a building full of people losing their lives.

"Okay then," Dean Blaine said, making a snap judgment to steer the thoughts of his class toward less chilling waters. "I'll now announce the pairs for the projects. You will have the rest of the class to discuss possible Heroes from the list I'll be posting in a minute, and the two of you have until the end of the week to let me know your pick. Don't hesitate, though; they are first



come, first serve, and each Hero may only be done by one team."

Dean Blaine produced a piece of paper and began calling out pairs of students. As each team was named the duo would rise from their seats and flag each other down from their respective positions, stopping only when one relocated to the other's area. Nick tried not to center too much on disappointment. If the list was already chosen then he couldn't use his power to affect the outcome. If he had known and had blasted out some luck during its creation the situation would have been different, but luck was only applicable to objects in motion. No amount of luck changed the dice roll once the results were written down. It would have been beneficial for Nick to land on Hershel or Vince's team and solidify the sense of friendship he had been crafting with them, but as Hershel was announced to be paired with someone named Alex and Vince was put with Will Murray, it became clear that Nick would be expanding his social circle. It could be worse, though; increased connections were rarely a bad thing.

"Next team," Dean Blaine announced. "Nicholas Campbell and Alice Adair."

"At least it's not the telepath," Nick mumbled under his breath. Humorously enough, Alice was muttering approximately the same thing from her own desk across the room. The two began the dance of waving, determining who would move over to the other's area, neither one particularly excited about their partner but each confident they hadn't gotten the shortest stick in the room.

Many might have believed that dubious honor went to Hershel, who drew up a seat next to his new partner.

"Hi," Hershel said. "I'm Hershel Daniels."

"Oh, I know," said the sandy-haired boy. "I heard all about the fight this weekend. I'm Alex, though. Alex Griffen."

"Nice to meet you, Alex," Hershel said. "So, I guess you already know about Roy then?"

"Totally," Alex said, nodding enthusiastically. "Seems like an awesome ability, turning into someone crazy strong and tough."

"It's... not as great as one might suspect," Hershel said delicately. He was hesitant to badmouth Roy at the moment. Roy had attended gym the day before, but he'd been different from usual: less proud, certainly, but less sure of himself as well. Hershel knew better than most what that was like, so the last thing he wanted to do was pile abuse onto his recovering alter ego. "It can

be fun, though, and it's rarely boring. What about you, Alex? What's your power?"

"Nothing too exciting," Alex replied. "I'm basically a Jedi."

## 34.

"Looks like we got Everest," Vince said, striding into the library and depositing his books on a small table occupied by a short boy wearing glasses.

"That's great!" Will, also known as the short boy wearing glasses, exclaimed. "I thought for sure someone would have beaten us to him."

"When I spoke with the dean he told me we were the third team to make our selection," Vince replied, taking his seat and spreading out the books. "I guess the others are taking their sweet time in picking a subject."

"Who else had been chosen?" Will asked as he unloaded the contents of his own backpack onto the table, cluttering it even further.

"Apparently Shane and some Amber girl took Captain Starlight, and Doc Nominal was chosen by guys named Gilbert and Adam," Vince recounted. Fortunately there hadn't been many names on the sign-up sheet, so the few that were present were easy to recall.

"Oh, I know Gilbert," Will said. "He and I are in the same physics class together above ground. Good guy, if a bit of a slacker on studying. No one else though, huh? I was sure that Alice girl who is always asking questions would be first in line."

"That's not an unfair assumption," Vince admitted. "She's working with Nick, though. I don't think they exactly dislike one another, but they never seem to talk much. Then again, I don't think any of us really talk a lot with Alice except in passing."

"She doesn't seem like she would lack social skills," Will observed.

"No, she doesn't; really the opposite," Vince said thoughtfully. "She's always polite and composed. I guess in the whirlwind of the first few weeks we just haven't had time to get to know one another."

"I imagine that's the case with many of us," Will said. "In fact, it's possible that is why Dean Blaine gave us this project in the first place. It does force us to expand our social circle a bit."

"You might be right," Vince agreed. "Though that still doesn't explain what's holding up Alice and Nick on choosing a Hero for their project."

\* \* \*

"I respectfully disagree," Alice said through a thin mask of patience. "I think Lord Pholos will make an excellent case of study for our project, and is not a 'bore in a cape' at all."

"Oh, come on," Nick replied, spinning his chair in a circle and staring up at the ceiling. "Do you know what Lord Pholos was before he got into the game? A manager for a paper clip company. Seriously, how could he possibly be more boring?"

"Maybe the fact that he was one of the few older men who became certified as a Hero is in itself an interesting story," Alice retorted.

"Great story, that one. He was born in a family that had religious disagreements with the existence of Supers so he was raised to pretend he was human. Then his wife leaves him at thirty, his normal world falls apart and he escapes into a new one, one where he can use his powers to have the fame and respect that eluded him in his younger years," Nick returned.

"That's... well... it's still... fine," Alice spat out bitterly.

The two of them had been at it for some time now, camped out in the common room of Melbrook, Alice making suggestions and Nick spearing holes in them. He had to admit, she'd picked a few that would have actually made exceptional projects, and that was the problem. Nick didn't want to be exceptional; he wanted to coast through this presentation with a middle-of-the-pack Hero that would earn him a middle-of-the-pack grade. Since Alice didn't know this, though, he was forced to play his character in an alternate direction. Instead of showing that he wanted an average presentation and grade, Nick was making himself out to be a perfectionist and knocking down any Hero suggestion that wasn't "good enough" for him and Alice to work on.

Nick was also finding a slight bit of amusement in watching Alice vainly try to conceal her mounting frustration. How this girl had even gotten the impression she was skilled in hiding her emotions and manipulating people was beyond Nick's impressive comprehension.

"Okay," Alice said after a moment to gather her composure. "Let's see what other options there are." She pulled out the Xeroxed list that Dean Blaine had provided each group, showing which Heroes were available for them to choose from. "How about The K?"

"Retired too young."

"Alphablaster?"

"Honestly? You want us to do a report on someone with vocabulary

based powers?"

Alice had to admit, even to her that one seemed pretty bad. "Well, what about Everest?" Alice asked.

"Perfect," Nick replied.

"Really?"

"Totally," Nick confirmed. "But Vince already texted me and told me that's the one he and his partner got approved to do."

"But... then why didn't you..." Alice began to stammer.

"Oh, relax," Nick assured her. "We'll find someone good."

"Well... well, I'm done!" Alice declared, dumping the pages in Nick's lap and stopping his slow circular turning. "You pick the next one and let's see if I think *your* choice is good enough."

Nick scooped up the pages and pretended to look through them. The truth was, he had memorized this list before he and Alice had even left Dean Blaine's classroom for gym. It had taken Alice a bit longer to break than he expected, but the disintegration of one's pride was always difficult to apply a realistic time frame to. She'd finally defaulted to the princess he knew lurked inside that socialite façade, though, and that meant he could get a topic chosen and be done with it.

"Ozarell lived an interesting life," Nick remarked offhandedly.

"Interesting enough?" Alice asked, crossing her arms and setting her jaw.

"There's always Lickotaur," Nick ventured once more.

Alice did nothing but raise an eyebrow.

"Okay, look," Nick said in his best I'm-being-humbled-by-this-experience voice. "It seems like you and I both have different ideas on who we should pick for this project. Agreed?"

Alice slowly nodded her head.

"But the one thing we can both agree on is that if we don't pick someone soon we're likely to end up with nothing but the dregs left as our options," Nick continued the train of thought.

"That's not entirely impossible," Alice acquiesced.

"So, rather than bickering back and forth all day, why don't we try a different method to pick our subject?" Nick asked.

"Just a wild guess here, you already have such a method in mind?" Alice asked, not bothering to mask her sarcasm.

"That I do," Nick said, breezing right past the accusation in her words. Instead he set the list down on the coffee table and produced a penny from his pocket. "Let's flip a coin on it."

"Like what, heads or tails on each name systematically as a veto system until we narrow it down to one name?"

"No, that would take forever," Nick chided. "I mean literally. I'll flip the penny and whatever name it lands on is the one we use."

"That is utterly ridiculous," Alice replied without hesitation.

"But more productive than fighting all afternoon," Nick pointed out. "Besides, it isn't as dumb as it seems. Remember, my power is controlling luck. If I max out my good luck in this situation then the penny should land on the best option for us."

"Uh huh," Alice scoffed skeptically. "And after less than a year of control you think you can use your abilities for something that abstract?"

"Well, I haven't tested it," Nick lied, "but theoretically it should be possible. What's it hurt to try at least?"

"Fine," Alice said after a calculating pause. "I reserve the right to veto whoever it lands on if I don't like it, though."

"I'll agree to that as long as we look them up and give them a thorough once over," Nick said. Alice gave him the nod, and with sudden dexterity he flipped the small copper coin into the air. As soon as it was out of his hand, he focused himself and poured his luck into the coin, willing it to come down on the best possible result. He was careful to breathe deep and do other mild physical gestures that the others hadn't picked up on yet. Nick had spent weeks before coming here creating fake tells that would crop up whenever he used his powers. The only real tell was difficult to miss, so he'd been fastidious in drawing attention away with the decoys.

The penny tumbled down onto the list, landing squarely on a single name. Alice and Nick both leaned over and looked down at the printed tuck beneath the coin.

Nick let out a low whistle. "Man, talk about the dregs."

\* \* \*

"So, you're a telepath?" Hershel asked.

"Nah, man. Jedi," Alex said once more. "You know, like the order of space knights created in films by the great George Lucas." The two of them were in a cafeteria getting dinner and discussing options for their project. In the course of the day Hershel had found that he had a surprising amount in common with his new project partner, including a love of sci-fi, video games, and vintage comic books. The one sticking point he kept coming back to was Alex's power, or at least Alex's description of the power.

"You can move things with your mind, and pick up thoughts and emotions, right?" Hershel asked.

"I know this sounds crazy, but to me it feels like I move things with the Force, not my mind. Other than that you're pretty close," Alex agreed with a cheerful head nod. "Plus I can sort of do the mind trick."

"The one where you put thoughts into weak or unfocused minds? That's the Jedi mind trick you're talking about?" Hershel tried to clarify.

"Yeah. I can make it work about ten percent of the time," Alex confirmed.

"So, one out of ten times you try to tell someone to do something and they do it?"

"Eventually," Alex said.

"You do realize that sounds a lot like a telepath and telekinetic," Hershel said carefully. "Not like the abilities of practitioners of a religion from a science fiction movie."

"Yeah, but it's not," Alex said simply. "I know what you're thinking, I've heard it since I was a kid. Every teacher and coach my parents hired to help me hone my powers tried to convince me it was my mind doing this stuff, not the Force."

"And they were unsuccessful I take it," Hershel noted.

"They were unsuccessful because they were wrong. If I try to focus my mind and make even a pencil move, nothing happens. But if I reach out to it with the Force, I can juggle weights and golf carts. I know myself and I know my power. Maybe it is because I've always seen it a certain way and it's too late to change, but in my head I'm a Jedi," Alex said once more, not forcefully, instead with a sense of deep conviction and confidence.

So there it was. Alex considered his powers to work as though he were a Jedi and would not budge one bit on the topic. It was an oddity, but then again, Hershel loved dressing up like an elf lord and defending his castle. If anyone should be able to understand sculpting one's own reality, it was him. Besides, it seemed likely that state of mind and perception were important for someone whose powers were linked to their brain.

"A real Jedi, huh? That's pretty cool," Hershel said, smiling and picking up the ketchup for his fries. "Anyway, who do you think we should do our project over?"



## 35.

"Oh dear," Will said, gazing at the glowing screen of his cell phone. "It seems I'll have to cut our study session short today."

"That's fine," Vince assured him. "I think we got a lot of good material for the project so far. We can pick up here tomorrow."

"I appreciate your understanding," Will said with a smile. He reached across the table and began scooping books and notes into his backpack.

"Did something come up?" Vince asked.

"You could say that. It seems my sister has been challenged to a ranking match, so I feel a bit compelled to be there in support," Will explained.

"I didn't know you had a sister," Vince commented, packing away his own things. If Will was heading out Vince felt he may as well do the same. He could get back above ground, grab some dinner, maybe even see Sasha for a bit before he tackled the rest of his work for the evening.

"Her name is Jill. It is purely speculation, but I've always believed our parents must have been sadists to give twins rhyming names," Will said.

"It's not really that bad," Vince lied. Will stopped packing, looked Vince in the eyes, and stared. "Okay, it's pretty bad," Vince said, breaking after mere seconds.

"I know," Will said simply, readying himself to leave. Vince was about finished as well, so they exited the library together and began walking toward the lifts and combat cells. The two had been holed up in the underground library, which was similar to the one on the regular campus but stocked with a somewhat different selection of reading material. Very few normal Lander students found themselves in need of books on how to deal with radioactive fallout or study ancient war formation techniques. In the HCP such things were considered required reading.

"Sooo," Vince said, awkwardness and a poor understanding of social convention forcing him to make small talk. "What are your sister's abilities?"

"She manipulates technology," Will answered.

"Like, she can turn on cars, or like she can become the Internet?"

"Somewhere in between," Will chuckled. "She can interface with

software, but only to a limited point. If you asked her to type on a computer without her hands, or drive a car from a block away, those things would be in her arsenal. Asking her to hack into the Pentagon would be well out of her reach, though. It's like she talks to the machines and asks them nicely to cooperate."

"That seems pretty useful," Vince said. "As long as you have plenty of tech around."

"At that point having a brother whose power is mechanical genius comes in rather handy," Will said.

"Yeah, I've seen some of the stuff you use in class. The self-writing pen seemed pretty awesome," Vince said.

Will shrugged. "It frees up my hands and lets me get written notes. The hardest part was designing it so it could balance continuously on the tip while moving."

"I bet," Vince agreed. "So with you building her gadgets and her being able to use them with a thought, I bet your sister is one dynamite fighter."

"She's good, but there are plenty better," Will admitted. "She only came in fourteenth in the initial ranking. Of course, as the gear I build for her improves and she learns to fight more effectively, I expect to see a significant rise in her ranks over the years."

"I'm sure you will," Vince encouraged. "What about your rank, though?"

"I'm not combat compatible," Will replied with open honesty. "I can build things ahead of the technological curve. There are some who don't even believe that should count me as a Super. I'll certainly never be able to match what the others can do on the front line of battle. I'll have my uses, though; they just won't be gauged on how well I throw a punch."

"If you're focused on the rhino charging at you, you're likely to miss the panther sneaking up on your rear," Vince said.

Will raised his eyebrows curiously.

"It's something my father used to say. It meant I should learn to use misdirection and keep myself aware at all times, but it seemed sort of applicable to your situation," Vince explained. "Just because you aren't a thick-skinned muscle-bound monster doesn't mean you aren't dangerous."

"True," Will said slowly. "Although I still feel my place on the

battlefield is supporting others in the background."

"Maybe it is," Vince agreed. "All that really matters is that you're happy with what you're doing and where you're going."

"And I am," Will said as they walked into the central hall. Vince saw the lifts at the south end and readied himself to head back above ground. Before he left, though, a question struck him.

"I hope your sister does well today," Vince said. "Who is she fighting, anyway?"

"One of the girls she shares a suite with. A friend named Sasha," Will told him. "She has pink streaks in her hair and super speed. Very difficult to miss."

Vince was in whole-hearted agreement as he changed his oriented direction and began walking next to Will once more, mind already racing ahead of him to the fight that was beginning in the combat cells.

## 36.

Since Vince had first met Sasha that day in the infirmary she had been perpetually light-hearted. Her emotional range seemed to consist of sassy, flirty, and spunky. This wasn't to say she never had her down moments, just that she seemed to carry everything, even sadness, with a strange sense of cheerful apathy. As though nothing mattered too much, like none of it could really touch her.

The girl Vince was gazing at through the observation window looked nothing like the one he had grown close to over the previous weeks. Oh, her face and hair were the same, as was her uniform, but the girl herself was utterly different. Gone was the smirk hidden in the angles of her face, the carefree posture, and the easy manner with which she moved. Her eyes were hard now, and focused. Every step she took as she and her opponent positioned themselves for the fight to come was calculated, careful, and delicate. It struck a memory within Vince of when he and his father had snuck into a zoo and Vince had gotten to see a pair of tigers. Sasha shared their same rippling gait, smooth and deliberate but at any moment able to attack.

The other girl in the cell, Jill, didn't seem to be taking things any lighter. She was a girl of medium height with chopped-short dirty blonde hair. Instead of the standard uniform, Jill was sporting something that looked a lot like a one-piece flight suit, except with baubles and electronics bulging out at random intervals. As the girls moved to their starting sides of the cell, Jill took a helmet she had carried in her arms and slipped it over her head, obscuring any sign of her face behind a black visor. Outside gear had to be approved, but so long as it corresponded to your power, it was permitted in official matches.

"I see they're taking each other quite seriously," Will commented. He and Vince were standing together to watch the fight, making sure to give the referee and a small girl who was presumably the healer ample room in which to act if necessary.

"Yeah," Vince agreed. "They are."

"So, Sasha is your girlfriend?" Will asked bluntly. If either one had been paying more attention they might have noticed the sudden swivel of the small girl's head toward their direction. Both had eyes only for what was on the other side of the glass, though, so her action went unobserved.

"Sort of. We haven't really talked about it or anything, but... yeah, pretty much," Vince said.

"I hope that we can maintain our affable partnership, regardless of the outcome of this fight," Will said.

Vince hesitated before he answered. "You think Jill's going to win,

don't you?"

"I don't know," Will replied. "I built the suit she's wearing, and I am very well informed of my sister's capabilities in combat, but when dealing with super speed, nothing is written in stone."

As the girls readied themselves, waiting for the referee's signal to start, Vince silently agreed with Will. Both of them seemed intensely focused on this match, and he didn't know which of them would be walking away from it. He doubted they did either.

"I don't have to take this personally if you don't," Vince said. "After all, this isn't a squabble; they're trying themselves against one another as warriors. Whoever loses, there's no shame here."

"Agreed," Will said. "Though I'd keep that little theory away from whichever actually does lose."

"Duh," Vince said with a nod of his head. Vince was young, foolhardy, and ambitious. That didn't make him utterly idiotic, though.

The referee pressed a small button and the dean's recorded voice began to play from within the cell. When it concluded, their match would begin. "Be ready," he said to the small girl at his side. "This one could easily end messy."

\* \* \*

Sasha adjusted her footing without taking her eyes off Jill. The proverbial bell had been rung, yet both of them stood steady, neither rushing forward to make the first move. Sasha adjusted again, wishing dearly that Jill's head wasn't hidden behind a helmet and visor. It wasn't that Sasha was so cutthroat that she would have gone for the face or the eyes (not to say that she wouldn't, though), it was that blocking the face took away a lot of unconscious tells. Eye movements, facial tics, even nostril flaring could often be that little extra advantage that meant the difference between a win and a loss.

Sasha took a step forward, then one back, gauging Jill's reaction. Her opponent moved back a hair, but otherwise kept her same stance. So that meant Jill was playing defensive, waiting for Sasha to make the first move. It was the smart play, the one Sasha would have made if the roles were reversed. Charging someone with super speed was a good way to go down fast. You fully commit to an attack, and before you realize it they've moved out of the way and turned your own momentum against you.

It seemed Sasha was stuck on the offensive. That was okay, though; it was the area Sasha was the most comfortable in anyway. Choosing an angle, Sasha accelerated into a blur and demolished the gap between her and Jill. She didn't make contact with her, though, instead opting to ring around her twice then come to a stop at her rear. Jill was half turned when Sasha halted. Sasha spat a curse under her breath. Jill's reaction time was good, and that

meant once she attacked, there was a possibility Jill could counter with whatever gizmos were hidden up her sleeves. Super speed was a wonderful gift, but its weakness was that it was hard to aim precisely going several hundred miles an hour. Sure, Sasha's perceptions were sped up somewhat - otherwise she'd never be able to maneuver with her talent - but there were limits. They increased proportionally: in the same way that it would be hard for a regular person to do something precise while he or she was running full speed, Sasha was bound by the same obstacle. If she wanted to do more than swing wild, she'd need to slow down significantly when she made her attack.

It wasn't ideal, but Sasha had picked this partner. She'd issued this challenge. It would move her up five ranks, into the range where she'd be eligible for combat. She narrowed her eyes slightly, clearly betraying her intention to attack. It didn't matter. If Jill could keep up, then she would; if she couldn't, then no amount of warning from Sasha would make the difference. It escaped her own thoughts that mere moments earlier she had been thinking about the advantages of reading facial tics, but before that realization could bob to the surface of her mind she was already running again.

Sasha didn't bolt in directly: that would have been ludicrous. Instead, she circled Jill, drawing progressively closer then pulling back. She pulled a few feints, seeing how quickly Jill reacted to her advances. The closer she got, though, the more confident Sasha grew. Jill was close on her blocks, but not quite there. If Sasha had followed through on one of her punches she would have definitely made contact. Sasha looped around again, this time committing to her attack mentally. She would pull up short and let loose a flurry of super-fast punches. Even if Jill did manage to block one, the other fist would gain momentum and connect at least five times before Jill would be able to react. Sasha put in one last bolt forward, then pulled back on the metaphorical throttle and let fly at Jill with both hands.

Those who were blessed with super speed had been given a significant measure of durability in the package with that gift. As such, their bodies could withstand moving and stopping at such high speeds. It meant that Sasha could punch flesh and bone with tremendous momentum and only suffer minimal damage herself. While it didn't work against harder materials, steel for example, she could easily handle regular combat. So when Sasha's fists connected with Jill's ribs, she felt a sense of elation that she'd gotten her blows through without Jill even coming close to blocking either hand. A millisecond after that, it dawned on her that Jill hadn't even tried to block. She might have speculated more about why as she continued to punch Jill if that had been an option, but unfortunately that's when Sasha's time ran out.

That next millisecond, you see, was when the pain started.

\* \* \*

"What happened?" Vince cried as Sasha violently flew back from Jill

and into the concrete wall.

"She electrified her suit at the moment of impact, giving your girl a devastating shock," Will said, his voice even but his tone not entirely hiding the distress he felt in his own stomach.

"She can do that?" Vince asked, eyes on Sasha's crumpled, twitching form.

"It was the only option she ever really had," Will confirmed. "Sasha was too fast for Jill to have a hope of hitting her with any other kind of weapon. The best bet she had was to use herself as bait and strike when Sasha made contact. It was a good idea, but it wasn't without its risks."

For the first time Vince let his eyes move away from Sasha and back to her opponent. Jill was hunched over; he could tell from the movement of her back she was breathing with arduous labor.

"My sister put all of the suit's power into that jolt," Will continued. "That means the electronic shields and dampeners were shut down. She took Sasha's blows full on and left herself completely vulnerable."

"I think her ribs are broken," Vince noted, a fresh note of empathic concern in his voice.

"At the least. She has no physical powers, so those blows affected her just like any other human. She should be okay for now, but I'd be distressed if the end of this match weren't in sight," Will admitted, gesturing to the referee.

Vince looked over, and realized the referee was methodically counting down from ten, eyes locked on Sasha's fallen form. If she couldn't get up before zero, this bout would be over and the girls could get healed. Vince actually felt a rush of relief as the referee dropped past the count of three. It sucked that Sasha lost, but right now his mind was solely fixated on getting to her and making sure she was okay. When the referee's hand struck the number two, though, the counting stopped. If that hadn't told him enough, the gasp from Will made the picture clear before Vince could turn to the window and see it.

Sure enough, Sasha was clawing her way up the concrete wall with one hand, slowly dragging herself vertical. The significance of this wasn't lost on anyone watching, least of all her opponent. Without hesitation Jill threw her hands up, signaling her surrender and the end of the match. With twin sighs of relief, Vince and Will bounded down the stairs to the door, eager to make sure everyone was all right.

### 37.

"I heard through the grapevine that Ms. Foster advanced her ranking this week," Mr. Numbers said as he moved his knight.

"Are we calling the weekly logs you get of all combat trials 'the grapevine' now?" Mary asked as she began contemplating her next move.

"Touché," Mr. Numbers replied. The two were sitting in the common room early Saturday morning. Thus far they were the only two up and around, save for Mr. Transport, who was off running errands. As soon as Mr. Numbers had stepped out of his room Mary had been waiting, chessboard in hand. So, after a cup of coffee, Mr. Numbers accepted her challenge and the duo began their second game of chess. Mr. Numbers took a sip of his coffee as Mary made her next move.

"I notice you're using both rooks normally this time," he commented.

"He's been fixed," Mary answered to the unasked question.

"Has he now," Mr. Numbers mumbled, measuring the board to plan his retaliation. "I also heard through the grapevine that Mr. Daniels' attitude has improved tremendously since his bout with Mr. Taylor. It seems he is punctual when attending gym and attentive to everything Coach George says to him. The only curious habit is that whenever he is running he makes strange hand motions."

"Motions similar to the ones learned in the foundation of a martial art? Say, ones that a person might work on constantly if they were trying to ingrain the movements as reflex in their brain, for example?" Mary asked.

"Precisely those," Mr. Numbers confirmed.

"How odd," Mary said neutrally. "It's your move."

"I'm aware," Mr. Numbers said, shifting one of his pawns. "So I take it you and your dorm mates will be meeting up with your partners to work on your projects today?"

"Hershel might; he and Alex have been eating together ever since they were paired up," Mary said. "If I recall correctly, Vince and Nick are spending the day watching a movie marathon in the boys' lounge, then Vince is celebrating Sasha's victory with her tonight."

"You seem very well-informed of your dorm mates' plans. And Alice?"

"Alice is going to contemplate many options, then ultimately spend her day sulking at the fact that she has no one to spend time with, despite that fact that her own fear of intimacy with others is the driving force behind that fact," Mary told him, moving her queen.

"You could always try to break through that fear and befriend her," Mr. Numbers pointed out.

"Others could. I'm too much too soon for her - like dropping an aqua-



phobic in the middle of the ocean. Befriending a telepath won't challenge her personal limitations and obsession for privacy, it will shatter them. Maybe one day, though. I think I would like that," Mary said.

"I see," Mr. Numbers said, moving his knight once more in order to set a trap. "So, which chess piece will you be fixing next?"

"Well, the others are a bit more complicated," Mary responded. "The bishop is easily as strong as the rook, albeit in a different way, but unlike the rook the bishop is afraid of his own strength. The knight doesn't understand that just because she isn't as outwardly dangerous as the other pieces doesn't mean she is useless. And of course the king doesn't see that his role is as a strategist, maybe even a leader; instead he is stuck on the perception of himself as vulnerable and weaker than anyone else on the board." Mary moved her king to illustrate the point, going only back and forth along the rear row as she had throughout the entire game.

"And the queen?" Mr. Numbers asked as he repressed a smile at Mary moving directly into his trap. She was an utter amateur, but a part of him still took a beat of pride away from every victory, regardless of its challenge or relevance.

"The queen is a very powerful piece," Mary said. "But she's not so strong that she can stand against the other army by herself."

"Indeed," Mr. Numbers agreed. "Checkmate."

"So it is," Mary noted. "Next week?"

"Not in the mood for another?"

"One total loss a week is all I can handle, I'm afraid," Mary said with a soft smile. "Besides, I think the rest of my day just became a lot fuller."

\* \* \*

Alice didn't hear Mary's declaration; she had already stormed off to her room. Having woken earlier than usual, Alice was on her way into the common room so she could get water from the kitchen when she realized she could vaguely overhear Mr. Numbers and Mary having a conversation. Never one to pass up the opportunity to gather information, Alice planted herself on the other side of the wall and strained to catch every word. When talk turned to her, though, and Mary had called out so perfectly exactly what her plans were and why they involved no other people, Alice all but stomped back into her bedroom, slamming the door and sitting down on her bed. She had been fuming ever since, her pride battling her against her rationale as she tried to make peace with the things Mary had said, a mental tornado that could only settle down on the trailer of one logical conclusion.

By the time Alice reached it, Mary had been waiting nearly half an hour.

## 38.

Two crisp knocks signaled Alice's arrival at Mary's door. Mary got up from her bed slowly and walked over to answer it. Of course, she could have just waited outside in the girls' lobby, or been waiting by the door when Alice knocked, but that would have made her foreknowledge of the arrival just a bit too apparent. While Alice was by no means simple enough to think Mary didn't have some inclination she was coming, she didn't want to talk about or acknowledge it. Mary was respecting those wishes; after all, Alice was here to offer something of an olive branch, so it was the least Mary could do.

"Yes?" Mary said as she pulled open her door.

"I'm heading into town today for some light shopping and lunch. Would you like to come along?" Alice asked, not without some stiffness in her voice.

"I'd love to," Mary replied with a warm grin. She stepped out and closed the door firmly behind her. "When do we leave?"

"Immediately," Alice said, glossing over the fact that Mary had physically responded to the answer before even asking the question. It was to be expected with a telepath. She'd known this when she decided to invite Mary along. It was part of the package, part of spending a day with a girl who could read her thoughts. Mary had been right about Alice avoiding her and about her having trouble connecting with people at college, but Mary had taken it too far when she said that Alice would be unable to make friends with a mind reader. The fact that Mary had been basing her deduction on Alice's actions or that it was a completely logical conclusion became utterly irrelevant in the face of one all-consuming truth that had burned its way through Alice's wounded pride and hidden shame.

That truth was simply this: No one told Alice Adair what she was or wasn't able to do.

"Let's hurry," Alice said. "The restaurant I'd like to visit fills up very early for lunch, so it's best if we're there as soon as possible."

"Of course," Mary nodded in agreement.

\* \* \*

"So what's on the docket?" Vince asked as he stepped into the boys' lounge, fresh bowl of popcorn in one hand and a pair of sodas in the other.

"*Zombie Prince 4*, *War Zombies 2*, *Hellsong: The Rise of the Zombie King*, and *How to Lose a Guy in 10 Days*," Nick said from his perch in a recliner, remote in hand and eyes fixed on the slowly loading screen.

"Should I even ask about the last one?"

"Hey man, that's a good film, and it provides excellent insight into the female perception of romance," Nick defended.

Vince sat down in a recliner next to Nick and put the popcorn on a table between the two, sliding over one soda as well. "I'm not buying it."

"Okay, fine; the girl at the video store was hot, and I didn't want her to think my cinematic taste was one-dimensional," Nick sighed.

"Despite the fact that it clearly is," Vince pointed out.

"Hey man, you don't know me entirely. Maybe I like romantic comedies. I could be very multi-layered," Nick said.

Vince crunched a kernel of popcorn and kicked his seat into the reclined position. "I'll believe it when I see it. So where's Hershel, anyway?"

Nick shrugged. "I think he and his project partner were grabbing lunch after doing some work this morning; they said they might stop in."

"Those guys are really determined to do well on that assignment, aren't they?" Vince asked.

"That or they have nothing better to do," Nick said. "Though I don't see the rush; we've still got weeks left. We should be spending more time thinking about what Halloween costumes we should be saving for or working on."

Vince snorted. "We're in college; you really think anyone actually cares about Halloween, let alone puts in effort on a costume?"

\* \* \*

"I'm leaning toward Cleopatra," Alice said as she sipped her espresso delicately. "Of course, there are a few famous Victorian characters I would enjoy portraying as well, but the drawing point is also the problem. Those gowns are so complex and elegant, and while they would be fun to wear, it would hardly be in the spirit of the holiday at our age."

"How so?" Mary asked politely. It had been a bit of a straining day for her so far. The lunch had been delicious and Alice was enjoyable enough company, but Mary wasn't used to asking clarifying questions or pretending she didn't already know the answers to things she might idly wonder. This habit of feigning ignorance was helping Alice feel more at ease with their time together, but it was at the cost of Mary's nerves.

"For girls our age attending a university, the accepted societal convention is that our costumes should be somewhat more... sensual than they were in our younger years," Alice replied.

"So we're supposed to dress slutty?"

"I prefer to think of it as we can get away with doing so judgment free," Alice said, a blatant smirk creeping across the side of her mouth.

"That is a good point," Mary agreed. "Although I don't know if it would fit my style. I was thinking I'd just be a mummy or something."

Alice looked at the girl sitting across the table from her, slowly working her way through a piece of cheesecake, and realized something that had never entered her mind before. Mary was insecure about the way she

looked. She'd always been so cheerily bizarre, so oddly confident, and seemed to be three steps ahead of everyone else that it had never occurred to Alice that a girl like Mary might suffer from something as mundane as a poor body image. It wasn't that she was unattractive, either: her amber eyes were striking, and her wild hair actually seemed to compliment her face. She was petite, too. It was easy to forget with the powerful energy Mary seemed to exude, but she was only about five foot two, with a lithe body that matched. In that moment, discovering her terrifying, invincible telepathic neighbor had a weakness, Alice felt something she had never genuinely expected. She felt a spark of a connection to Mary.

"A mummy might be fun," Alice said kindly. "I bet we can find something that flatters you more than that, though."

Mary raised an eyebrow. "You want to go costume shopping?"

"Why not? I said we would go shopping anyway, and besides, it's early October so the stores should be open. We'll have fun." Alice gave Mary a sincere smile, and with a crash Mary realized she had just maneuvered herself into spending a Saturday being dressed up like Alice's personal doll.

Mary was a firm believer that necessity and duty should trump one's own desires. That said, she still found herself thankful that Alice didn't have telepathy as well, otherwise all the cursing going on in Mary's head might have been a tad difficult to explain.

## 39.

"Well, gory as that was, I think this is where I bail out for the day," Vince said, rising from his chair and stretching deeply while the ending credits for the previous movie rolled across the screen.

"Ah, come on, we've still got like two more!" Nick protested.

"Yeah," Hershel agreed. Hershel and Alex had joined up with them halfway through the first movie, finding the siren song of slacking while watching slasher cinema too alluring to resist in favor of homework.

"And I'm certain they'll be wonderful movies," Vince placated. "I've got to get heading over to Sasha's, though, remember? We're celebrating her rise in rank."

"So bring her back," Nick countered. "What better way to celebrate life than to observe those who are lacking in it?"

"You want me to congratulate the girl I'm dating on a serious accomplishment by making her watch bad zombie movies?"

"Vince," Nick began in an offputtingly serious tone, "a woman who won't celebrate with zombie movies isn't a woman you want to keep around. Trust me, that's gospel truth right there."

"Amen," Alex chimed in.

Vince stared into the sleek lenses of his friend's glasses for a moment, then shook his head and barked out a laugh. "Okay, okay. You guys win; I'll bring it up to her as an option. But if she says no then consider me gone for the night."

"That seems fair," Hershel said.

"Yeah, yeah, fair schmare," Nick said with a wave as he dragged himself out of his own chair. "We may as well get some dinner ourselves while Vince is applying the zombie barometer to his relationship."

"Zombie barometer? Really?" Vince asked as the other two stood from their reclined positions to join them.

Nick simply gave a small nod and replied with two words. "Gospel. Truth."

The four hungry young Supers headed out of the boys' lounge and made a path for the entrance hall, nearly plowing right into Mary and Alice as the two girls entered the common room.

"Oh good," Alice said briskly. "I'm glad you're all here. I have something we need to talk about. Just let me go put away our packages." With that, Alice scooped up Mary's bags along with her own and moved with surprising swiftness into the girls' lounge.

"Actually, we were sort of heading out," Vince began calling after her.

"You're staying," said Mary with a thou-shalt-not-question-me-for-

I've-been-stuck-trying-on-clothes-all-day-and-I-am-desperate-to-share-the-pain tone. Okay, Vince may not have picked up on all of the subtlety contained in her words, but the gist of it came through.

"I guess we have a few minutes to spare," Vince acquiesced. Hershel and Nick might have had fleeting thoughts of protesting on their own, but one look from Mary's weary yet scorching eyes told them quite clearly that they'd be better off minding their own business.

"Um, well, I guess I'll go head over to the dining hall and grab us a table," Alex offered.

"I'm sure you're welcome to stay," Nick assured him. "I'm equally sure that being able to leave is the privilege in this case, though, so do what you want."

"Yeah, I'll just meet up with you guys after," Alex said, taking in a long stare at Mary's haggard stance and making a (wise) snap decision. "Give me a call."

"Will do," Hershel assured him, although he wondered how much longer he would be able to stay out. Weekends were historically Roy's turf, but he hadn't been lobbying for them nearly as hard since his bout with Chad. In fact, Roy hadn't been doing much of anything besides working on the training Mary had given him. It was beginning to concern Hershel a bit, but for the moment he was grateful to have been handed the chance for a sense of normalcy, regardless of how fleeting it might turn out to be.

Alice emerged a few moments after Alex departed, taking a position at the front of the room and gesturing for the others to sit down around her. She made no comment on Alex leaving, taking it on faith that they had ushered him out the door in a properly diplomatic fashion. Interestingly enough, it never occurred to her that their method had been forewarning him so he could escape to freedom.

"Now then, I want to talk to you all about Halloween," Alice began once everyone had awkwardly settled in. "Mary and I were looking at some costume options today, and it occurred to me that there aren't many celebration options for people in our position."

"Wait, the two of you went shopping? When did I miss that turn in the road?" Nick interrupted.

"Annnnnyway," Alice continued. "My point is that we aren't old enough to drink at the bars, and it's not like the school has many fun activities. I thought we should talk about some possible options."

"Um, well, I hate to say it, but I think my plans for Halloween are already set," Hershel said. "Roy has been looking forward to that for months, and it's really always been his favorite holiday."

"That seems like something of an odd choice," Vince commented.

"He gets to walk around in a costume lacking a shirt and hit on women

dressed in far more appealing clothing than they would normally wear, all while hopping from bar to bar finding an endless supply of co-eds," Hershel explained.

"That does make a lot more sense," Nick agreed.

"Yeah," Vince said, distracted. The mention of Roy in a bar had reminded him of something he'd been curious about the night they had gone to Whiskey Shallows. "Hey Hershel, how come Roy can drink out in public like that? He's the same age as you, so shouldn't that be illegal?"

"Oh, Roy has a fake ID. Given how mature he looks, no one ever really questions it when he goes out," Hershel explained.

"Ahem," Alice said, clearing her throat purposefully. "If we're quite done discussing yet another way that Roy is violating rules, perhaps we can move back to my original point and discuss what we might want to do for Halloween?"

"I've got a better question," Nick said. "Why are you assuming we'll all want to do something together? I mean, we've all done our own thing for the past few weeks and that's been working out pretty well. How about we all just do whatever we want for Halloween?"

There was a beat of silence as Alice used every drop of self-control she had to keep from blushing. She'd gotten so wrapped up in shopping with Mary today, Alice had managed to forget that the rest of her dorm mates were her cohabitants, not really her friends. With a swift and disproportionate sense of embarrassment, she imagined how silly she must seem, suddenly trying to rally everyone together out of the blue. Urgently she grasped for anything she could say to gracefully exit the conversation and retreat to her room where she could forget all about this little foray in social expansion.

"We've all been 'doing our own thing' because we were getting acclimated to campus and the program. That doesn't mean we shouldn't consider each other friends and ignore our sense of unity. We're the only people on this entire campus that know what kind of horror it is to have powers and not be able to control them. We all lived through that, we all dealt with that, and right now we're all doing our best to make sure no one else ever knows about that part of our past. If that doesn't make us at least connected enough to consult together on holiday plans, then I don't think we'll be bonded to anyone. Ever," Mary said sternly.

Nick stared across at her and Mary matched his gaze. Many people would have been subtly intimidated by not being able to see Nick's eyes, but for Mary it was no concern at all. She didn't need to look into his eyes to see into his head. And Nick knew it.

"Okay, okay," Nick said with a shrug. "It was just a question. So Alice, I assume you had some ideas for what we could do?"

"Oh, um, yes," Alice said, recovering quickly. Outwardly she went

through the few options she'd compiled thus far, gauging everyone's reactions to the possible celebrations. Inwardly, though, she was dealing with the sense of shock and overwhelming gratitude she felt for Mary. In all of her life, Alice couldn't think of one time anyone else had stood up for her like that. It was a very novel, very nice sensation. And somewhere, in the deepest parts of her mind, the mask of friendship she had worn toward the tiny telepath became just a few degrees closer to reality.



## 40.

"You have got to be kidding me! More books? Where are you even finding these things?" Nick wailed as Alice walked into the common room with a pile of books bundled in her arms.

"Yeah, that's the appropriate reaction here, bitch about me finding more resources. Don't even pause for a minute to consider helping the lady in need," Alice snapped.

"I'm a proponent of gender equality," Nick shot back. The duo was meeting to work on their group project yet again, though in this case "work" might have been a somewhat loose definition. It more often consisted of Nick finding ways to occupy himself outside of the subject at hand and Alice berating him for it as her method of research avoidance. Neither appeared particularly adept at knuckling down for hard work, but as the due date drew closer, Alice found her stress level rising in proportion, so she was determined they make headway with what time they had left.

"Such a gentleman," Alice mumbled as she set the books down and took her seat. She'd tried to maintain her usual implacably polite demeanor for the first week or so, but something about Nick seemed to render her usual defense inaccessible.

"Hey, you're the one that campaigned for it; I'm just respecting your wishes."

"If you're granting wishes I'd love for you to pick up a damn book and help me with this. Our presentation is in two more weeks!" Alice said through gritted teeth.

"Yeah, but Halloween is in a week and a half, so shouldn't we really be focusing more on what we're going to do costume-wise?" Nick replied.

Alice took a deep breath. "I've already gotten mine prepared, because unlike you, I plan ahead of time. By that same token, I'd also like to plan ahead for what we're going to say when standing in front of the entire freshman class, presenting the entire life of a superhero we know next to nothing about."

"What's to know? I mean, the guy is pretty infamous as is. He was part of the world's most respected team of Heroes, then one day out of the blue he goes rogue, kills his partner, and gets taken down by the rest of his team. It's one of the most famous stories of any Hero. Do you really think we're going

to shed any new light or insight into one of the most speculated-on events of the past century?" Nick asked.

"I think we'd damn sure better try," Alice responded. "We picked this topic, we told Dean Blaine this was the guy we wanted. If we go in there with this report half-assed, it reflects horribly on us. Besides, he can't be all that infamous. I've never heard of him."

"Tell me you're joking," Nick said. "You've never heard of Globe the Traitor? He's, like, the favorite cautionary tale of everyone in the Super community. 'Don't grow too full of yourself or you'll end up like Globe.' Your parents never told you about him?"

"I was raised with other educational goals. Besides, since until this year it was never even considered that I might one day gain control and become a Super, such cautionary tales would hardly have been necessary. So what happened with him, anyway?" Alice asked.

"I thought you'd been researching him."

"I have," she said defensively. "I simply started with his early life, which was oddly difficult to find information on. I haven't gotten to him joining a team of Heroes yet, let alone betraying them."

"I can try to fill you in," Nick said. "You have to understand that not a whole lot is really known about the details, though. It was a pretty big PR mess for the Super community, and I think a lot of the records were sealed and information was hidden away."

"That might explain why I'm having such trouble finding information about his early life."

"True point," Nick agreed. "Anyway, from what I know, Globe was part of a team of Heroes around fifteen years ago, give or take a few. They were really powerful - I mean, out of the five members, two were considered so strong that it was thought they might grow into Armageddon Class."

"Those are the ones who could actually destroy the world if left unchecked, correct?"

"Bingo," Nick confirmed. "So Globe was one of those two, and the story is that he got a little too full of himself. He felt like he was doing all of the work and carrying his team. Those feelings snowballed over time, and eventually he decided he didn't need them anymore."

"So he quit the team," Alice surmised.

“That’s one way to put it. Another would be to say that he murdered Intra, one of his teammates, and tried to kill the other three as well before they were eventually able to kill him instead. It was one hell of a resignation letter.”

“That’s awful,” Alice gasped. “He turned on his own team?”

“Even worse, Intra was apparently his best friend. The two of them were partners before they joined up with the other three members,” Nick added.

“It seems odd, though,” Alice remarked. “I mean, I guess I can see growing unhappy with a team, but why not just leave? Why end your relationship in murder?”

“Hence why I said this is one of the most speculated-on events in modern history. It doesn’t really make sense; there must have been some other motivations going on behind the scenes. We don’t know what they were, though, so the whole thing just ends up being one big head-scratching mystery,” Nick said.

“Hmm,” Alice said, the wheels turning in her head. “Maybe we can take an angle of looking at it from the point of view of the rest of the team. My father is well-connected, it’s possible he could pull some strings and line up a few interviews for it.”

“He’d have to be *really* well connected.”

“Just tell me the name of the other team members,” Alice said, just a twitch too quickly to pass over Nick’s comment nonchalantly.

“We only have their code names, of course,” Nick said. “Even in death the identity of a Hero is protected. If memory serves, though, the other team members were Intra, the one who was killed, as well as Black Hole and Shimmerpath. There was one more, too.”

“We know of two. Is the last one terribly important?” Alice asked.

“Couldn’t hurt,” Nick replied. “Let me think a second. He had something to do with changing the composition of things.”

Alice felt her stomach take a very abrupt and deliberate trip in the southern direction. “You know, Nick, I think we’re fine with just these two-”

“The Alchemist!” Nick declared triumphantly. “The fifth member was a man by the name of The Alchemist. Anyway, after Globe went nuts, the team was disbanded and everyone left alive disappeared from the world of

Supers. Think your dad would be able to find them?”

“I’m unfortunately certain of it,” Alice said through gritted teeth. “My father is Charles Adair, but back in his Hero days, he went by the code name of The Alchemist.”

“Ohhh,” Nick said as understanding seemed to dawn on him. “Awkwaaaard.”

## 41.

"Still no answer," Alice all but swore as she paced the room, snapping her cell phone shut.

"Ain't that always the way? Parents are always calling when you're busy, but the minute you actually need to talk they're nowhere to be found," Nick commented from his sprawled out position on the couch.

"Oh this is just so... so him!" Alice spat out, dropping into a chair with a huff.

"In all fairness to your dad, it's not like he knows you're trying to reach him this hard," Nick said.

"Not that. I mean... well, yes, him being busy and unavailable is classic, too, but I meant the thing with his old teammate. That is just so Daddy," Alice grumbled.

"He makes a habit of helping to kill murderous teammates, huh?"

"Don't be a jackass," Alice snapped. "It's so like him to have this huge part of his life and tell me nothing about it. I mean, I can sort of understand why he might not want to tell me about what happened with Globe: I'm sure that was really traumatic. But I never even knew he belonged to a team. I thought he just got his certification and did a little Hero work to help his career. Now it turns out there's yet another part of his life he didn't bother to share with me. The funniest part about this is that as much I want to feel mad, I can't. I can't because I don't even feel surprised by it anymore." Alice let out a long, slow breath, deflating as it exited her lungs.

"I, um, actually sort of know what you mean," Nick ventured cautiously. "Ms. Pips isn't really big on sharing either."

"I thought your last name was Campbell?" Alice asked.

"It is," Nick confirmed. "It was my parents' last name. The woman who raised me is named Ms. Pips, though."

"Oh," Alice said simply, grabbing the implication immediately.

"Yeah," Nick said, glossing onward. "I mean, don't get me wrong, I love Ms. Pips and she loves me. A guy couldn't ask for a better godmother. She's just not the type that gushes anything. Feelings, personal history, dreams; really, any of that crap is kept close to the vest. You know, kind of

like your dad, or that's how it seems at least."

"It seems right," Alice agreed. "He's a better dad when he's around, but you don't build a multi-billion dollar lifestyle by having lots of free time to hang out with your defective daughter."

"Defective?"

"Not anymore, I guess. Just still sort of think of myself that way. From ages three to eighteen I was damaged goods. That sort of mindset takes a little time to fade," Alice admitted.

"It really does," Nick concurred. "What about your mom? Is she around more?"

"I never actually met my mom," Alice said softly. "She passed away giving birth to me."

"I'm sorry," Nick said reflexively.

"It's okay. It was a long time ago. Besides, I never met her, so it's hard to miss her," Alice reassured him.

Nick pulled himself to a more upright sitting position on the couch and looked across at Alice. "You're a terrible liar," he said.

"I beg your pardon?" Alice wasn't able to keep the surprise off of her face.

"My parents died in a car accident when I was a few months old. I might have met them, but I have no memory of them at all. I've spent my entire life being raised by Ms. Pips without ever knowing my birth parents. I know too well how easy it is to miss someone you've never met," Nick said.

Alice didn't have a response for that, so instead she fiddled with her phone.

"Going to try your dad again?"

"Doesn't seem like much point to it," Alice replied. "I guess we might as well go back to me nagging and you slacking off."

"Do we have to? I thought we were bonding there for a moment," Nick whined.

"We were, which is why I'm nipping it in the bud," Alice countered. She picked up one of her books and tossed another at Nick. To her credit, she didn't aim too directly for his head, which might have been taken as a sign of

fondness.

"Ouch!" Nick yelped.

Then again, maybe not.

\* \* \*

"How did I never realize you two were suitemates?" Vince asked as he plugged in the movie and rejoined Sasha and Jill on their couch.

"I do spend a lot of time downstairs training," Jill said, handing a bowl of popcorn to Sasha so it was accessible to everyone on the couch.

"Still seems odd. Then again, I still don't know who shares a room with you, so I guess I can't be that surprised," Vince noted.

"My roommate is a girl named Amber. She has an older boyfriend who lives off campus, so she spends most of her free time with him," Jill answered. "It's nice, actually, a bit like having a single room."

"Wait, so the other girl, Amber, is she like us?"

"Of course, Vince; they almost always room Supers together," Jill giggled. Vince had been surprised by her bubbly nature when they'd actually gotten to talk after her and Sasha's fight. She'd been so cold and hard when in combat; but then again, the same could be said for Sasha. More than anything he was glad the two girls had been able to shake hands and continue on with their apparent friendship after the bout had been decided. He wondered how many other Supers were able to maintain such amiable relationships after challenges. His suspicion was very few.

"Okay, it's set up," Will called from behind the television.

"Sweet," Sasha said. "And you're sure this won't fry our TV, right?"

"93 percent sure," Will answered as he emerged from the tangled depths of the mythical land known as "Behind the TV."

"That still seems like a pretty significant margin of error," Sasha said.

"Relax; if my brother designed it, it won't blow anything up. Unless it's supposed to blow something up. Anyway, the point is, even if it doesn't work, it won't be destructive. He's religious about using safeguards," Jill assured Sasha.

"What do you mean 'even if it doesn't work'?" Will asked as he plunked down in a chair next to the couch.

“Nobody bats a thousand, little brother.”

“We’re twins,” Will pointed out.

“Yes, but I’m older by two minutes,” Jill replied, sticking out her tongue.

“Stupid sister rushing out the birth canal,” Will grumbled. “So, what cinematic masterpiece are we using to test my new device?”

“*Flesh Reaper 4: Hell’s Reaping*,” Vince told him.

There was a beat of silence before Will’s strangled voice managed to eke out one lone word: “*Really?*”

“Hey, it’s like a week and a half before Halloween, the video store was pretty heavily favoring the horror section. I did the best I could,” Vince defended.

“You understand what I built, right? It’s a three dimensional immersion device. We’re not just talking about pictures standing off the screen, we’re talking about being in the center of the film. We’re talking about seeing the landscape of it in every direction, of sitting on this couch underwater, or in space, or on Mount Fuji. We’re going to be utterly visually submerged in this world, and the world you chose for that is *Flesh Reaper 3*?” Will asked.

“*Flesh Reaper 4*,” Vince corrected him. “Besides, it’ll be fun to have something a little scary. All I’m doing for the real Halloween is going to some party that Alice found.”

“That doesn’t sound so bad,” Jill said.

“Maybe not. I don’t know, I’ve never to been to one of these before. Apparently it’s hosted by one of the local frats, but everyone is welcome. You just have to be in costume and pay the five-buck entry charge,” Vince said with a shrug.

“Are you going?” Jill asked Sasha.

“Already working on my costume,” Sasha said with a naughty smirk.

“You two are more than welcome,” Vince said. “Again, I don’t know if it will be worth the five bucks, but if you’ve got nothing else to do it might be fun.”

“We will certainly keep that in mind,” Will said. “At any rate, I think it’s time to put my new invention through a test drive.”



“Woo!” Sasha yelled.

“Do it!” Vince joined in.

“Um, go bro?” Jill said less enthusiastically.

“Ladies and gentleman, I present to you an entirely new way to watch movies, a way that is closer to living them than merely observing the pictures pass before your eyes,” Will said, firing up the remote. “Years from now, when everyone is using these devices, tonight will be a historic night, the night when the first lucky viewers were given the privilege of experiencing a new level of glory in the film... *Flesh Reaper*.” Will’s steam died off noticeably when he got to the movie title.

“*Flesh Reaper 4*,” Vince corrected.

## 42.

A week and change later found the male Melbrook residents, along with a few additions, gathering in the common room for one last wardrobe check before venturing off into the haunted night.

“Okay, pilgrims, y’all about ready to getting on the trail?” The questions came from a cowboy standing toward the center of the room. He wore faded jeans, a white linen shirt, and a brown duster along with a matching cowboy hat. Slung low across his waist was a pair of gun belts with a plastic six-shooter tucked into each side. He had a three-day scruff on his face and casual posture, adding a sense of realism to the costume. The whole thing was marred, though, by the presence of a pair of black sunglasses across his eyes.

“Seriously, Nick?” Vince said, adjusted his chainmail. Vince was dressed as a knight, complete with plastic sword, plastic chainmail, and a plastic helmet, all spray-painted grey to look like metal. The effect was not altogether successful. “If you’re going to all the trouble of using an accent would it be so bad to take off the glasses?”

“Yes,” Nick said quickly. “Plus, they add to the effect. Pardner.”

“It does add a touch of dashing,” Will commented from his seat on the couch. Will was wearing a tailored black tuxedo, complimented with an array of hi-tech gadgets tucked away within its folds and pockets, for his costume of a spy.

“I don’t think anyone will notice,” Roy tossed in, flexing his pecks. Roy was dressed as what one could only assume was either some sort of ancient gladiator or a male escort that catered to a very specific fetish. He wore little more than an expanded loin cloth and sandals, leaving the rest of muscled body intentionally exposed. At present he was oiling up his chest before moving on to the arms.

Vince bit back a remark that wanted to snake out. Roy was still an annoying cock-bag, but he had toned it down tremendously since his fight with Chad. They rarely saw him anymore; he was almost always training when he was in control of the body. When he was around, though, he seemed to make a genuine effort not to verbally abuse those around him directly. Indirectly it still seemed a free-for-all, but progress was progress.

“What’s taking the girls so long?” Alex asked. He was standing near the hallway, wearing a white tunic with black pants underneath a brown robe.

A familiar tubular metal device was fashioned to his hip, and anyone who wasn't utterly ignorant of classic sci-fi cinema was able to recognize his costume in a heartbeat.

"Is that a real question?" Roy asked. "I mean, you have met women at some point in your life, right?"

"I'm sure they just want everything to look perfect," Vince cut in. "I know Sasha spent a lot of time on her costume, and I'm sure the others did as well."

"That we did," Mary said as the door to the girls' side opened and the women began trickling out from their lounge. Mary was dressed as a gypsy, wearing long flowing garments, a scarf, and rings of coins that jingled when she walked. After her was Alice, who sported a nun's habit and dress, though it fit her form in ways the sisterhood would surely not have approved of, given that there was a slit up the side and bottom of it was not even near her knees.

"Wow, someone jumped whole hog onto the slutty train," Nick observed when Alice came into his field of vision.

Alice merely gave a shrug. "It is Halloween, after all."

"True, why a nun though? Pardner," Nick asked.

"It's kind of an inside joke. Think about it for a while," Alice replied.

"I sincerely hope my sister showed a touch more prudence in selecting her ensemble," Will commented.

"Not that it's any of your business, little brother, but I think I walked a nice line," Jill said as she emerged through the door. Jill was decked out in what appeared to be a torn orange prisoner's jumpsuit. While select parts of it were shredded or removed to create an aesthetical appeal given Jill's slender frame, it was definitely more conservative than Alice's, while not being quite as covering as Mary's.

Sasha came out last, wearing a jumpsuit as well. Hers was in one piece, and unlike Jill's it was definitely sewn to fit her figure. In fact, a phrase like "skin-tight" would not have found itself out of place in describing her ensemble. It was decorated with checkered flags and logos of various products. Aside from that her hair was flared out as though the wind had been blowing through it and she sported a pair of aviator sunglasses across her face.

“Hey, the glasses thing is sort of my shtick,” Nick said.

“And when you make them look this good you can have that shtick back,” Sasha rebutted.

“Touché,” Nick said, then hastily added, “Pardner.”

“That’s not getting old,” Vince sighed, then turned his attention to Sasha. “You look fantastic.”

“Thanks. I thought fast girl, racecar driver, there’s something of a connection there,” she said. “Plus, I had it down to two options, and this was the one I could do and be sexy.”

“What was the other?” Vince asked.

“I was going to wear a football helmet and drag along a bunch of broken things and tell everyone I was a Powered,” Sasha said, all but cackling at her own humor. The others joined in, though not quite so enthusiastically, and it should be noted that Alex didn’t laugh at all. As for the Melbrook residents... well, they were working very hard to fit in. Let us say that in their defense and leave it there.

“Yeah, that would have been a good one,” Alice lied. “Anyway, let’s get going. How are we doing cars?”

The group then began the sizeable chore that is transporting many people in limited vehicles to the same location. It was solved in relatively short order, and the freshmen departed to the raucous Halloween party. Their spirits were high, but five of them were a bit lower than they had been. On a day of costumes and pretend, they’d been reminded their outfits were a touch redundant, because they were already lying to everyone about who they really were.

## 43.

The warehouse that the fraternity had rented was... well, just that. It was a warehouse in the industrial district of Lander that someone had clearly deemed unfit for use, but that someone else (likely someone well-compensated) deemed more than adequate to house hundreds of young bright minds and extensive musical equipment.

Still, none of the partygoers paid much attention to lack of structural integrity. Instead they lined up outside, allowing local police to check their IDs and mark their hands appropriately, then depositing five dollars with the doorman and entering the bass-thumping building already nearly crushed with bodies.

Once inside the aesthetics were slightly better, in the same sense that being chased by a cheetah is slightly better than being chased by a bear because at least you won't have to run for long from the cheetah. The walls were multi-colored tones of grey and faded white that might as well have been grey, and the concrete floors provided poor acoustical absorption from the massive sound system set up near the rear of the building. Overpriced drink and food carts littered the walls, with a few selling alcoholic beverages to those with unmarked hands, as well as those with marked hands who were willing to pay double under the table. Near these concession areas stood a smattering of tables and chairs, though most of the warehouse was dedicated to room for the young ones to dance and mingle. It was a scene that anyone with culture and sense would dub a new level of hell.

"This place is awesome!" Vince cried out, the others nodding in agreement as they holed up at one of the few open tables and took a moment to collect their bearings. "I can't believe they can finance this whole party with just five bucks per person. That's really nice of them."

"I'd say less nice, more intelligent," Will corrected.

"How so?" Vince asked.

In response Will pointed to an area of the warehouse where a small section of couches had been set up and roped off. Sitting on these plush seats were a collections of males in costume, as well as a rotating selection of females entering and leaving.

"This is the best place to go for all of us underage students and they know it. So know they've got access to hundreds of young girls, away from home for the first time and looking to spread their wings of experimentation.

On top of that, they're in positions of power in this small one-building kingdom, able to expel people at will. It's a sweet setup when you think about it," Will explained.

"That seems a bit underhanded when you point it out," Vince said.

"War is hell, and mating is the greatest war any man will ever fight," Will shot back.

"Besides, what do you care who gets first crack at the girls with self-esteem and daddy issues? You've got your own dysfunctional lady right here," Sasha jumped in, putting her hand on Vince's knee and squeezing gently.

"That's great for you two, but some of us need to work a room to know who we're taking home tonight," Roy said, rising from the table and locating the nearest vendor with alcohol. It might have been Vince's imagination, but he could have sworn Roy shot Mary a questioning look before setting out on his own. Even stranger, though, was that he was almost positive she responded to his gaze with a small affirmative nod. He shook it off as a mere misinterpretation as Roy began weaving his way through the crowd, not unsurprisingly drawing looks of admiration from many of the female attendees.

"I hate to say it, but he has a point," Alex said. "This seems like a great opportunity to meet some new girls; hell, that's part of why I came. I just wish Hershel were here, too."

"Trust me, he wouldn't be much help in that department," Nick told him. "Besides, I'll come wing for you. Chicks totally dig the shades."

"Thanks," Alex said sincerely. "I've had a little trouble getting into my groove up here. It's harder to snag a date than it was in high school."

"You just gotta get confident, buddy," Nick assured. "That's all any lady wants."

"You're probably right," Alex agreed, rising to his feet with Nick following suit. "I guess the biggest difference is I never had to try before. I mean, back then, everyone knew about my... extraordinary talents, so most of the girls were always hitting on me."

"Being regular sucks," Nick agreed, throwing an arm around Alex's shoulders and dragging him off into the crowd. "Let's try my extraordinary talent. I call it 'lying'."

“What about you guys?” Vince asked the remainder of the table once Nick and Alex had departed.

“I have a girlfriend back home,” Will told him. “And my understanding of college courtship says it is traditional for the women to wait for a man to make the first move on them.”

“Shitty, but true,” Jill confirmed. “So you two are just stuck with us.”

“Oh assballs,” Sasha swore.

“Geez, did you want to be alone that bad?” Alice asked.

“Huh? Oh, no, no. Not that. Sorry,” Sasha said. “I just realized I forgot my chapstick in Alice’s car.”

“I’ll go get it,” Vince volunteered. “Alice, you want to come with or just have me use the keys?”

In response Alice pulled out her keys and slid them across the table with a light jingling sound. “I understand the need for protected lips, but my ass is settled and getting up in this outfit is an ordeal just to keep myself covered.”

“Thanks, Alice,” Sasha said, snagging the keys and handing them to Vince. “And thank you, my big strong knight.”

Vince accepted the keys and her praise with a sheepish grin, then got up and began fighting his way against the current to exit the building. It took some doing, but he finally reached the other side of the entrance, confirmed with the doorman he would just be exiting to retrieve something from the car, and made his way into the parking lot.

The October air was surprisingly refreshing after the small amount of time he’d spent sweltering inside the warehouse. He made his way down the street, savoring the sweet crispness and realizing how much he missed being outdoors on nights like these. He’d adapted so quickly to living in one place and sleeping indoors all the time, yet as his feet slapped against the pavement, a small wave of nostalgia crashed against him. Maybe he would see what sort of camping options Lander had nearby. He was sure at least of a few of his friends would be interested in spending a night among the trees.

If Vince had been a bit more focused on the task at hand and a bit less lost in his haze of memories and potential plans for the future, it’s entirely possible he would have heard the figure sneaking up behind him in time to react. That was not the case, however, and so as Vince rounded the side-street

to the parking lot where Alice's car was located, he felt a blast of freezing energy smash against his lower back, frosting over his legs and sticking him in place. The next blast hit his upper back, locking his arms and reinforcing the restriction on his torso.

"You'd think a guy like you would learn to watch his back," said Michael's all-too-familiar-by-this-point voice.

"S-S-S-orry," Vince chattered though his rapidly cooling jaw. "I d-d-on't think lik-k-ke a c-c-coward."

"I've gotten really sick of that mouth of yours, Sucker Punch," Michael sneered as he circled around to Vince's front. Vince snorted a laugh out through the cold and Michael's eyes narrowed. "What's so funny?"

"Ir-rony," Vince answered, slowly letting his reserve of heat pour out all over his body, melting the ice on contact with his skin.

"I'm glad you got a good chuckle," Michael taunted. "See, I figured something out about you. You might be a good fighter, but you're weak as shit. All you had was one punch when we fought. So even if you've got a little fire in you, I'm betting if I wrap you in ice ten inches thick you won't be able to burn your way out of it."

"You b-b-bet wrong," Vince lied, trying valiantly to keep the rush of fear off of his face.

"Could be," Michael agreed. "Let's find out."



## 44.

Most eighteen-year-old men would feel at least a bit self-conscious to be eighty percent uncovered and coated in oil at a crowded costumed social event. Then again, Roy Daniels had never been especially similar to other people his age. Perhaps that was why as he took a tour around the dance floor, sipping on a beer, he savored all the looks and glances people were throwing his way. At no point did the idea that anyone found his costume, or the large amount of well-muscled body that it exposed, to be in any way unattractive cross his mind. Roy's ego had undoubtedly taken a hit at his loss to Chad some weeks earlier, but that was only the part of his esteem tethered to fighting. When it came to his looks, that mountain of security was still utterly unmoved.

Roy pulled up to new vendor in order to refresh his beer supply. He'd done a few tours of the room now, and had selected the five women that he felt were at the top of the attractiveness scale. Roy had shown patience, and it had paid off, because three of those women had arrived after he had. It was always important to make sure you waited to find the best, because if something better came along and you were already mid-game, it was a huge pain in the ass to start over. Roy was willing to do a fair few things for new tail, but working harder than he absolutely had to was not one of those things.

"I totally thought that line would work," Nick's familiar voice complained as he and Alex joined in the line behind Roy to purchase drinks.

"Traditionally 'nice shoes, want to fuck?' is used as a joke, not a real line," Alex explained to him.

"Still, I felt the slap was a bit much," Nick added, rubbing his cheek.

"I take you girls... er, that you're striking out with the girls?" Roy asked with a half-turn, catching himself mid-sentence with the belittling terminology he was accustomed to using. Mary had left no wiggle room for that one; it was fully off-limits.

"Striking out is such vulgar terminology," Nick replied. "It implies that we're playing a game, which would make these women prizes to be won. I think we can all agree they're intelligent, independent beings who deserve to be held in higher esteem than that."

"You do realize there aren't any girls in earshot, don't you?" Roy asked.

“Oh. Yeah, them hoes be shutting us down,” Nick shrugged.

“Word,” Alex seconded.

“I can’t say I’m surprised. Nick, you’re wearing sunglasses at night in a party, and Alex is dressed up like someone from a sci-fi movie,” Roy pointed out.

“Chicks dig the shades,” Nick shot back.

“That’s why you’re standing in line with another guy right now?” Roy countered.

“I don’t see you doing much better, Romeo,” Nick said. “You’re waiting in line by yourself.”

“I’m choosing my target carefully,” Roy told him. “There’s a lot of talent here tonight. I want to make sure I’m getting the biggest piece of chicken on the table.”

Nick and Alex responded with very questioning, very confused looks.

“It’s a southern metaphor,” Roy explained.

“Dude. You’re from Chicago,” Nick said.

“Hershel is from Chicago. I’m from the deep south.”

“That makes, quite literally, no sense at all,” Nick said.

“Word,” Alex seconded again.

“Look, I don’t have to explain myself to you guys. The point is I’m picking the best girl here to go home with. That’s the only reason I’m solo right now,” Roy said, stepping forward as the boy in front of him finished setting his money onto the counter.

“So that’s it, huh? You’ll just pick the best one and of course she’ll go home with you?” Alex asked.

“Yup,” Roy said as he selected his beer.

“This I’ve got to see,” Nick said.

“Feel free,” Roy agreed. “Just keep your distance while the master works. As for me, I’ve picked my target, so it’s go time.”

\* \* \*

“Looks like I wasn’t so wrong after all,” Michael chuckled. Vince

couldn't reply, unfortunately, since Michael had frozen him almost totally solid. The only part of his body still exposed was the top half of his head, allowing him to breathe. And, of course, to stay conscious and suffer. The rest of his body was caked in inches of ice. The only thing keeping him from hypothermia was the slow pulse of heat he was releasing all across his body intermittently. Vince only had a few lighters' worth of fire in him, though, and his reserves were running dangerously low.

"You look kind of silly," Michael commented as he surveyed his work. "I think it suits you, though. It's like a living piece of art, a testament to what happens when you take on Michael Clark. I feel like you've learned your lesson tonight, haven't you?"

Vince stared at his bald tormentor, unsure of exactly how Michael was expecting him to convey surrender.

"Oh, right, froze your jaw there. Okay, I'll make it simple. Just blink twice to show me you understand, and I think we can finally be done with this."

Vince locked eyes with Michael. The smart thing was to blink twice, get free, and come at Michael again on another day. A day when he wasn't totally helpless and fast running out of energy, a day when he had a real chance at taking this cock-bag down. It was the most basic strategic decision he could have been presented with.

Vince didn't blink. His eyelid didn't even twitch.

"That's a shame, Vince; I really thought you and I had come to an understanding. I guess we need to continue the education, though," Michael sighed. He pulled back his fist and focused his energy.

"I have severe doubts that this is a sanctioned match," said a deep, male voice from behind Michael. Before Michael was able to turn and see who the speaker was, two beams of orange energy had snared him. One wrapped around his forearm and the other grabbed his torso, yanking him up into the air.

"Who the fuck are you?" Michael spit, jerking and twisting his arm to get free.

"My friends call me Thomas," the speaker said, stepping into Vince's view. "I have a feeling you won't be counting yourself as one of those, though." Thomas was a dark-skinned male, one Vince recognized from gym and their Ethics class. He was dressed as a Native American, and both of his hands were outstretched, a beam of orange energy emanating from each one.

"I've got him restrained," Thomas called out. "You guys check on his victim."

Vince heard three people approaching behind him. He would have turned to look if he'd possessed a full range of motion. As it was, all he could do was listen.

"He's not a victim," Michael yelled. "We were just having a fight."

"An unsanctioned fight, in the middle of an alleyway where anyone could have seen you using your powers, and where it looks like you're tormenting him after having won a long time ago. Yeah, this seems real legit," Thomas said calmly

"I think he's okay," called out a deep female voice. "Violet's going to weaken the ice so we can pull him out."

"I wouldn't be averse to a little help here," Thomas called back. "He's still struggling, and this guy isn't the number three rank for nothing."

"I've got to work on the ice and we'll need Camille as soon as I'm done," said a new female voice, presumably Violet.

"That just leaves me," said the original female voice. She walked past Vince as she approached Michael. It was a girl he easily recognized from class. Thought she was dressed as some sort of Viking woman, the tightly braided hair pulled back gave her away as Stella, the girl in class that always asked questions without raising her hand. She strode right over to where Michael was struggling a foot or so off the ground and punched him in the throat. His twisting and jerking was immediately replaced by rasping and choking for air.

"That was excessive force," Thomas chided her.

"No, it was the best solution," Stella argued. "If I'd said to let him down and we'd fought him all honorably then he would have used his full power, so we would have had to do the same, and it would have caused a lot of property damage as well as creating a damn good chance we'd all be outed as Supers. Sometimes the only option is a quick punch to the throat."

"I'm almost got him over here," said Violet, still behind Vince. He wasn't sure what she was doing, but he could feel the ice behind him cracking apart and giving way. All at once a chunk of it fell away and Vince felt himself tipping backwards. Two pairs of arms caught him and laid him down upon the pavement. His energy almost completely depleted and his life out of danger, Vince did the only thing he was capable of at that point.

“Thank you,” Vince mumbled weakly, and then passed out into sweet oblivion.

## 45.

Vince came around a few minutes later, shivering slightly, and pulled himself up off the concrete.

“Whoa there, buddy, I’d go slow if I were you. Camille patched you up, but cold has a way of seeping in on people,” said the dark-skinned boy dressed as a Native American.

“I’m getting used to it,” Vince said. “Sadly.”

“I take it you and Baldy have a history?”

“Only in his sad, angry little cue ball of a head,” Vince said. “Thanks for saving me, by the way.”

“Of course,” Thomas said. “It was an illegal match and you were down. There was nothing else to do.”

“Well, I’m still glad you wandered by. My name is Vince, by the way.”

“Thomas,” Thomas replied, extending a hand. Vince accepted and shook it.

“So I heard,” Vince said. “Where are the rest of your friends?”

“Camille went to get some help, and Violet and Stella are escorting Frosty back to campus,” Thomas told him. “He’ll be less of an ass after he sleeps off the alcohol... we hope.”

“Michael was drunk?” Vince said in surprise.

“My understanding is that most students have a pre-party a bit before these events, especially the underage ones who can’t buy anything during. It seems he went a little overboard,” Thomas said.

“I guess I feel a little bit better,” Vince said. “Also, you should call your friend Camille. I’m going to be fine, I don’t need any more help, and I really don’t want to cause a fuss.”

“You sure about that? You took a pretty nasty beating there.”

“I’m sure,” Vince confirmed. “Your healer took care of nearly everything except the exhaustion. Right now all I want to do is catch a bus home and sleep for a day.”

"Your call, I guess," Thomas shrugged.

"That it is," Vince agreed. "Thanks again for saving me though. I can't express how glad I am you guys stopped him."

"A person was in need," Thomas replied. "That's the exact reason we're going through this training anyway, right? Besides, once we report him on Monday I'm pretty sure you won't have to worry about Michael anymore."

"Report him?" Vince asked.

"Of course. He broke the rules," Thomas answered.

"Sure, but I mean I'm okay and everything. Like I said, I'd rather avoid a fuss," Vince said.

"He broke the rules," Thomas said again. "That means he has to be reported so he can face the consequences."

"Yes... yes, you're right, of course," Vince agreed. "By all means make the report on Monday. If you'll excuse me, though, I really am feeling drained from my ordeal."

"Of course; go home and rest. Are you sure you don't need any more help?"

"I'm positive," Vince reassured him. "But tell your friends thanks as well from me."

"Will do," Thomas agreed.

\* \* \*

"Mr. Reynolds," Dean Blaine called as Vince entered Ethics of Heroism on Tuesday. "May I speak with you a moment?"

"Um, sure," Vince said awkwardly. He had pretty good inclination what this was going to be about and it was something he'd been hoping dearly would slide by unnoticed.

"It seems Coach George would like you to go to the gym today instead of attending my class," Dean Blaine said, any possible resentment at his class being snubbed hidden artfully in the smile that stretched across his face.

"Is that okay?" Vince asked. "I mean, we start presentations today."

"You and Mr. Murray are scheduled for Thursday since, as you know, we weren't able to fit all of them into just one class. I do hope you'll hurry

back to watch the others if possible, but if Coach George feels this is important enough to pull you from class, then you should make sure and give him your full attention," Dean Blaine assured him.

No other option coming to mind, Vince waded against the incoming crowd and made his way to the gymnasium. Nick noticed idly that Vince was exiting instead of entering, but he'd been suspecting something was up since Saturday, anyway. Vince wasn't the kind of guy to flake out, so when he'd vanished early in the night only to text Sasha that he'd gotten suddenly ill and had caught a bus home, it was obvious he was lying. Inconvenient too, since he'd had Alice's keys when he ditched. Fortunately Sasha was able to dash over and recover them, so the pilgrimage home had been possible.

Whatever Vince was dealing with obviously was tethered to what happened Saturday, but Nick's attention was focused on his task at hand for the day. He and Alice were scheduled to present, and he had a bad feeling he knew exactly the spot they were going in. Sure enough, as the class settled into their seats, Alice's tall frame remained standing, speaking hurriedly to Dean Blaine and gesturing to the mountain of poster-board she had dragged along with her. One might think she hadn't heard of a slideshow program, but one would be wrong. The posters were supplemental to the slide show. She'd worked extra hard to get them done in time. As she motioned for him to come up to the front, Nick groaned inwardly. He should have picked a worse subject to do the report over. Not even Globe was going to drag them down enough with her putting out this kind of effort.

"Class, it seems one of today's teams brought along some materials that would be inconvenient to store, so they've kindly volunteered to start us off today," Dean Blaine told the students as Alice ordered Nick around behind him, the duo quickly setting up their posters and loading the presentation onto the computer. "I'm sure all of you feel just devastated by this loss of opportunity, but please try to keep your disappointment to yourself."

A polite chuckle rippled through the class. People learn early on to laugh at the jokes of those in charge, and that goes for Supers just as much as humans. Dean Blaine cast a glance back at Alice, who flashed him a grin and a thumbs-up, so he continued. "It seems our group is ready. I urge you to give them your full attention and ask any relevant questions once they are finished. Remember, participation is a vital part of my class."

With that, Dean Blaine took a seat at a desk formerly occupied by one of the ever-mounting number of students who had washed out. Nick cleared his throat and stepped to the center of the classroom. He'd managed to talk Alice into letting him speak on the grounds that he had more practice at it



than she (truth) and that he would give a better presentation overall because of that (lie). The reality was that he wanted to control the flow of the presentation, hindering where he could and helping it if he had to. Nick was determined to squeak out of this incident as nothing more than an afterthought in the minds of the class, no matter how much effort it took.

"Alice and I chose something of a controversial Hero for our presentation," Nick began. "In fact, I think many would argue whether he should still even be rightly categorized as one. Certainly there have been outcries by some to strip him of any semblance of that title, even in reference to the years he served dutifully as one. There is some validity to those opinions, just as there is some in the beliefs of a few people that this Hero was a victim of some deeper problem, or that his fall from grace was orchestrated. Today, we are going to look over the known life, and ultimately the demise, of a Hero with the code name Globe."

Nick's monologue was interrupted by a loud CRACK that echoed through the room. The source was immediately visible, as a part of Chad's desk fell heavily to the floor. Chad hastily rose from his seat.

"I'm so sorry about the interruption," Chad apologized to Nick. "My hand slipped while I was resting it on the corner of my desk. I think I must be feeling ill, so I'll excuse myself to the infirmary and let you get back to your work. Again, very sorry." Without so much as a glance for confirmation to Dean Blaine, Chad strode out of the room.

"Okay... right then," Nick said, damning that blond bastard for making sure this presentation would stick in the mind of every single person in attendance. "Anyway, Globe first appeared as the top graduate in his year of the Hero Certification Program..."

## 46.

"I assume you know why you're here, Vince," Coach George said as the silver-haired youth entered his sparse office and took a seat down on the opposite end of George's considerably wide desk.

"No, sir," Vince lied.

"Good boy," Coach George complimented him. "Never give away more information than you have to. No sense in confessing to a crime I might not know about."

Vince blinked in surprise, unsure of how to react to such a statement.

"It's the right strategy," Coach George continued. "Unfortunately for you, it's not any good in this case. You're here because of the fight you and Michael had on Saturday night."

"I'm not sure what you mean," Vince said.

"The point at which a lie is exposed is when you give it up for a better one. You don't cling on to the one that's no good anymore. Now, I've got a full report from Thomas Castillo about how he and some friends pulled your ass out of a mini-glacier. Let's be clear here: I didn't call you in to dock you or punish you for having an unsanctioned fight," Coach George informed him.

"I... I wouldn't really call a jumping much of a fight," Vince admitted, taking the coach's advice and giving up on denial.

"Get in enough of them and you will," Coach George assured him. "Now, I don't really care that much about the fighting. I know we make a big deal in the beginning, but that's mostly just to cover our own asses legally. My concern is about what I read in this report."

"What do you mean?" Vince asked.

"I mean Michael had you dead to rights. It didn't sound like there was any real struggle between you two from how unharmed Michael was. I know what your power is, kid, and I know they never successfully found a limit on how much energy you can absorb. You should have at least given that little nutjob a run for his money. So I want to know how much power you had stored up when that guy surprised you," Coach George demanded.

"Enough," Vince said, crossing his arms and sitting back in the chair.

"See, that's the one amount we know you didn't have. Enough," Coach George shot back. "You threw one fire punch in your ranking matches, and this time I'm guessing you only had enough heat stored up to fight hypothermia while you got the shit knocked out of you. We both know you can do a lot more than this, so I want an answer. Why are you trying to scrape by on the bare minimum with your power?"

"I'm not," Vince replied. "I work as hard as anyone out there. I run, I lift, I train, I do everything you ask to get stronger and prepare myself for combat."

"You do," Coach George agreed. "That's why I'm taking the time out of my day to have this conversation rather than just drumming you out of the program immediately."

Vince's eyes widened slightly. He'd been expecting a lot of things, but expulsion from the program had seemed too extreme for just one fight.

"I have... issues with my power sometimes," Vince said carefully.

Coach George looked at him for a moment, then spoke again in a lower tone. "Look, kid; let's just put our cards on the table here. I know about you and the rest of your petri dish dorm. Of course they were going to tell the people who were supposed to help teach you." The last part was proactive, accurately anticipating the question Vince had been about to interrupt him with. "So you say you've got issues with your power? Well, I've got issues with people who can't use the very thing that qualifies them for this course in the first place. This is your only chance; if I were you, I'd try really hard to convince me there's some reason you should stay."

George had expected another snappy comeback, but to his surprise the kid lowered his head a bit and seemed to genuinely think. Most men his age would have assumed that it was a bluff and made up some crap to throw back as an answer, but the kid with the goofy silver hair was being rational about it. George readied himself to actually listen to what Vince would say, a courtesy he wouldn't have normally extended.

"If the procedure isn't permanent, and Alice loses control, what happens?" Vince asked at last.

"She starts free-floating around the place again," Coach George replied.

"And Mary?"

"She won't be able to block out the voices."

"What about Nick and Hershel?" Vince asked again.

"Nick, god only knows what, and Hershel would start shifting uncontrollably to Roy again," Coach George answered. "I assume you're building toward a point here?"

"I am," Vince answered. "And this is it: If the procedure isn't permanent, if I lose control again like I did before, what happens?"

"You have an entire faculty of capable Supers to keep you in check," Coach George told him.

"A faculty that can only react," Vince pointed out. "You can't anticipate. That means for you to contain me, something has to have already happened. If it happens when I'm down here, then it's probably no big deal. But I have normal classes too, and I eat lunch in the dining halls, and that's time I spend with regular humans. Humans who wouldn't be able to survive a sudden wildfire or a lightning bolt to the chest."

"So you're scared of hurting other people?" Coach George asked.

"Yes. I'm terrified of it," Vince said. "I want to be a Hero to help people, to use my abilities the way my dad always told me I should. I want it more than I've wanted anything in my life, aside from control of my powers. I will work hard, and I will do what you say, but I won't absorb more energy than I have to until I'm positive that I won't lose that control. If you have to kick me out then you have to kick me out. I'm not endangering innocent people for the sake of my own ambition, though."

George stared down the skinny boy sitting across from him. All the training had stacked a little muscle on his shoulders, but he still gave off a lean, almost shrimpy impression. Physically this kid was nothing worth taking a second look at. His eyes, though, that was a whole other story. George had seen a lot of tough talk in his years of dealing with kids who grew up stronger than everyone else. What he hadn't seen near enough of was eyes filled with determination and integrity, eyes like the blue set that were meeting his gaze from across the table.

"I'll give you one year," Coach George said eventually. "You can keep up this tentative crap until the end of your freshman year. As long as you keep up the work in gym and the start of combat training I think you can keep pace with the slower half of the class."

"Really?" Vince asked dumbly, unable to disguise the shock in his voice.

"Yeah, really," Coach George confirmed. "Be warned, though, this is all you get. At the end of this year you either make peace with the necessity of using your power or don't bother coming back. Starting second year that attitude won't just put you at risk, but people who'll be depending on you as well."

"I understand," Vince nodded.

"Good. Now get out of here; you've still got a few minutes before gym," Coach George said, gesturing to the door.

"I will. Um, thanks," Vince said lamely.

"Thank me by working hard," Coach George told him, and Vince exited his office with a quick nod of agreement. George, on the other hand, leaned back in his chair and savored the few moments of solitude he had left before he'd have to ride and demean the remainder of the freshman class. He reflected back on his talk with Vince, going through the boy's logic and motivation in his head once more.

"I'll say this for him," Coach George mumbled out loud. "That kid has the same brass balls as his dad."

## 47.

“How are the presentations going?” Mr. Numbers asked as he entered Dean Blaine’s office.

“Fine, save for one student having a very bad reaction to the name Globe,” Dean Blaine replied. “Where’s your other half? I asked to see both of you.”

“He’s in Moscow tending to some company business,” Mr. Numbers lied. Mr. Transport was actually in Kenya, but Dean Blaine didn’t need to know that.

“I suppose the job must come first,” Dean Blaine acknowledged. “Still, I assume you’ll provide him with a full record of our conversation?”

“Of course.”

“Excellent. I really wanted you down here to touch base on your charges and see how they’re adapting outside of my class,” Dean Blaine said.

“They’re doing better,” Mr. Numbers replied. “Mary and Alice seem to be pursuing a friendship with one another, albeit at a halting pace. The others are growing more interconnected as well, and even Roy has been on better behavior. Of course, the project helped them with branching out their social circle quite a bit. Thank you again for that.”

“It was a small concession to assist my students,” Dean Blaine said, waving it off. “It was a good idea, too. I might actually continue using it in years to come. It gave a lot of the remaining students an excuse to get to know one another.”

“On that note, how many do we have left?”

“We’re down to approximately forty students. I suspect by the time George finishes the number will be closer to thirty-five. Usually those who can survive the first semester make it to the end of freshman year,” Dean Blaine said.

“Fifty percent left? That’s a pretty high rate for a freshman class. Is George going easy on them?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“Quite the contrary: he seems to get harsher as the years go by, and Persephone hardly tempers him at all anymore,” Dean Blaine commented.

“That’s good, though,” Mr. Numbers said. “Anyone who can’t even

make it through this will have a breakdown two weeks into being a Hero.”

“Agreed,” Dean Blaine said. “It’s a very difficult job. I was quite thrilled to leave the combat field once this administration position became available.”

“I’m surprised they don’t try to bring you back. Your power is so unique, it made the difference in a lot of fights,” Mr. Numbers said.

“Well, thank you, but now I’m sure there’s another Hero with a unique power to make that difference. Times change, and we must change with them. Those of us not blessed with enhanced physical attributes are lucky if we can make it to thirty as a Hero. There were some good times, but this is where I do my good now. To that effect, is there any other assistance you require from my end to help bond the students?”

“I think the project accomplished what we needed,” Mr. Numbers told him. “Besides, Mary is doing an excellent job bringing them together on her own, and Mr. Transport and I have a few activities planned to strengthen their unity.”

“I do hope one of those activities will get Mr. Reynolds to begin using his powers,” Dean Blaine commented.

“Ah yes, Vince. We’re unsure what to do about him. He’s clearly afraid of his own abilities, or afraid the treatment will prove to be temporary,” Mr. Numbers said.

“That would match well with the report I received from George,” Dean Blaine agreed.

“Normally, we would have him work through those fears, but in this case they’re actually very realistic things to be scared of. This will be something he either finds a way through, or he doesn’t,” Mr. Numbers said.

“It would be a shame to lose a Super with such potential, but that is the way things go,” Dean Blaine said. “At any rate, I thank you for your time, and tell Mr. Transport next time I schedule a meeting I expect him to make time for it.”

“Of course, Dean,” Mr. Numbers said respectfully. “Oh, one quick question. You said one of the students had a bad reaction to the name Globe. Which student?”

“Chad Taylor, the number one male rank.”

“Very odd,” Mr. Numbers agreed. “I just wanted to be sure it wasn’t

one of our charges. I'll leave you to your work. Have a good day, Dean Blaine."

"And you, Mr. Numbers," Dean Blaine echoed.

Mr. Numbers stepped out of the office and made his way through the underground area toward the lifts. Finally away from the dean, his mind was kicking back into its regular gear. Just as well, too; Mr. Numbers now had some additional research on his plate.

First and foremost, though, Mr. Numbers needed to get their plans for winter break squared away. He and Mr. Transport had hatched a lovely scheme to bond their students together, but it was taking far more prep work than originally expected. If it worked, though, then it would be well worth the effort. Unfortunately, that effort was eating what little free time he possessed. He hadn't even had time to pop by town and pick up more puzzles. It was frustrating to be a man as brilliant as Mr. Numbers with nothing to take his mind off of that brilliance.



## 48.

“Because there are certain things about my life you just don’t need to know,” said the exasperated voice from the other end of the cell phone.

“But Daddy, don’t you think the fact that you were part of a really famous team of Heroes might have been something your daughter would have wanted to know about?” Alice shot back. After weeks of trying she had finally managed to track down her father and get him on the phone, though the results weren’t panning out exactly as lucratively as she’d expected.

“Given what we were famous for, no; I felt it was something better left in the past,” Charles told her. “And given that many of the records about the incident were sealed and we agreed to keep it confidential, that only added to my motivation. Now, I’m in the middle of a very important meeting here, so was there anything else you needed?”

“No, Daddy. That was it,” Alice said stiffly.

“Good then. Study hard, finals are right around the corner.”

“I will, Daddy.”

“Of course. I love you, Alice, I’ll call you soon,” Charles said.

“Love you, too,” Alice all but mumbled. There was the click of disconnection and Alice was just sitting in her room holding a cell phone. She wasn’t sure why she felt any surprise: it had always been like this. He was a kind father, and he was good to her when he was around, but he always so sectioned off, so sealed away. Alice often wondered what it was like to have warmth in a person’s life. Not just tolerance or caring, but genuine joy at someone’s company. She wasn’t sure, but she suspected she was getting closer to it here than she ever had at home, and as bad her phone call had been, that thought cheered her slightly. Well, that and the fact that she was still riding high on getting the best grade in the class so far for their presentations. Nick had seemed oddly unexcited by it, but it felt good knowing she had set the bar for the others to follow. There were still more presentations Thursday, but she was confident that they would not be easily dethroned.

A soft knock rapped at the door.

“Come in, Mary,” Alice called. The boys couldn’t get into the girls’ lounge area unless they were let in, so the only person who could be knocking on her door was her fellow Melbrook female.

The door was pushed open and Mary entered. “Hey, the guys are going to the dining hall in, like, ten minutes. I thought I’d see if you wanted to come,” Mary offered.

Alice did her best to keep a sneer of disgust from rippling across her face. Her little understanding of dormitory food held it in the esteem of old vomit and fresh excrement. Still, it was nearing the end of the first semester, and she’d still yet to set foot in one of these establishments. Not to mention it was where the rest of her... maybe not yet friends, but associates, gathered to dine, so if she was serious about trying to get closer to people, this was one of her best opportunities.

“I think I would like that very much,” Alice lied.

Mary chuckled. “You know, it really isn’t that bad.”

“We shall see,” Alice said skeptically, rising from her bed and sliding on her shoes.

In truth, the food wasn’t that bad. And what was lacking in culinary refinement was made up for with the experience of sitting around with people Alice was growing ever more comfortable with, complaining and laughing about their classes and day-to-day lives. It would have been an overall positive experience except for the fact that a girl who has been raised with dieticians and organic diets most of her life has a very poor tolerance for things deep fried in grease.

Alice would never admit it, but as she spent the next few hours unwillingly regurgitating her last meal (along with a few others), she still felt like it had been an overall good idea to eat with the others. She also made a mental note that from here on out she would be bringing her own damn food.

\* \* \*

“Thanks you for that wonderful presentation on Lord Pholos, Mr. Riley and Ms. Dixon,” Dean Blaine said as the two students bowed to polite applause from the class. Eventually they collected their materials and went to their seats, so Dean Blaine retook his customary spot at the front of the classroom.

“That concludes our presentations, and I do hope you all got a lot out of doing them,” Dean Blaine said, addressing the class.

“Actually, yeah,” Stella interrupted in her usual style. “It put things in a new perspective to actually see some of the hard calls our guy had to make in his career. Even though they worked out, they might not have. That’s some

crazy kind of pressure.”

“Precisely what I wanted you to realize,” Dean Blaine said with a smile. “We have a tremendous program here for getting your bodies in the condition necessary to be Heroes. The harder part, in my opinion, is training your minds to understand what a Hero is and what they should strive for. It’s a lot of responsibility, and the stress from it has broken more than one Super with awe-inspiring abilities.

“Now, we’ve put a lot of time into this project, but after today we’ll be easing up on the throttle a bit,” Dean Blaine continued. “We’ll still be having our discussions, of course, but I understand you all have finals in your other classes to prepare for. Since this course runs for two semesters, what you just did counts as the mid-term for the class, but you can think of it as the final for this semester.”

There wasn’t quite cheering from the class, but there was a noticeable elevation of everyone’s mood. Finding out they could cross a class off of their finals list early was welcome news to any student. Ever.

“I’ll still expect you to all show up and participate, of course,” Dean Blaine clarified. “I just want you to know there won’t be any other projects this semester. There is one particularly important class you’ll need to attend, though. I’ve lined up a guest speaker for next Tuesday’s class, and I expect full attendance. That means mental and physical. This will be an important step in developing a Hero’s mindset, so I want you to come sharp and ready to listen.”

“Who’s the speaker?” Stella asked.

“If I were going to tell you, don’t you think I would have mentioned it in that extensive preamble?” Dean Blaine retorted.

“Point,” Stella said, leaning back in her chair.

“The speaker is a surprise, but I hope you will take my word that their words will be worth hearing. Grade-shatteringly worth hearing, in fact,” Dean Blaine said, adding no inflection to his voice. The meaning came through loud and clear though. Miss this class, and find a new reason to be at Lander.

## 49.

“So what do you think he’s got planned for Tuesday?” Vince asked Nick as the two flopped down in the boys’ lounge after gym.

“Hookers,” Nick replied without a pause.

“You think the dean is going to bring hookers to a class centered on ethics?”

“A man can dream,” Nick sighed longingly.

Vince shook his head, a habit that was growing more and more frequent the longer he knew Nick. “I’m just glad we’re done with the graded work in his class for the semester. My other classes are starting to seem a lot scarier now that it’s almost finals time.”

“I know what you mean,” Nick half-lied. He did understand Vince’s plight from an objective standpoint, it was just one that he had never found himself in.

“I think most of my weekend will be spent meeting up with others in the class and getting a study group organized,” Vince speculated. “Hopefully if we share knowledge I can cram enough between now and then to scrape through.”

“Don’t worry too much about that,” Nick told him.

“You think it’ll be okay?”

“I have no idea; I just think you should be worrying more about whatever test they’ll give us in gym and less about ones with the highest danger potential of a paper cut,” Nick explained.

“Why would gym do a test? The combat matches are at the end of the year,” Vince pointed out. “We’re only halfway there.”

Nick could have pointed out that after the break was when the class format would change and students would no longer be able to battle to change their ranks, so it was only logical that the coaches would utilize one last testing activity before deciding who would be combat and who wouldn’t. He didn’t, though. Instead he just said, “It’s a chance to torture us. You see them just letting that pass by?”

“I hate to say it, but you make a point,” Vince admitted. “Thanks for that, by the way. Now I’m even more stressed.”

“Always here to help,” Nick chuckled.

“At least you have an ace in the hole,” Vince said. “I mean, worst case scenario, you can crank up your luck and just fill in test answers randomly. I bet that power comes in really handy.”

\* \* \*

The ten-year-old boy sitting at the blackjack table took a sip of his soda, but otherwise kept his eyes intent on the game. He had sandy hair and was a little tall for his age, though it was clear he still had ample growing left to do. The boy wore a striped collared shirt and jeans, along with a pair of black framed glasses he had to keep pushing up onto the bridge of his nose. The only other people at the table were the dealer, a woman who had money but not much sense or sobriety, and a well-built balding man wearing a black suit.

“So why exactly is your son sitting at a blackjack table in the middle of the day?” Ms. Anders asked. She was nervous, but doing her best not to show it. She was new to the Las Vegas branch of Child Protective Services, so of course when the time for Ms. Pips’ yearly review had come around, it was Ms. Anders who’d been handed the job. Unfortunately, Ms. Anders wasn’t quite new enough not to have heard any rumors, so while she’d been willing to come, it hadn’t been without a large sense of hesitation that was now slowly eroding into fear. The two women were sitting at a small table a few feet away from where the boy was watching the blackjack game.

“Because I have to work,” Ms. Pips answered. “And unless you’ve found a reliable sitter service in this town, I think you answered your own question.”

“I more meant why is Nick not in school today? It’s April, so summer break isn’t for another month,” Ms. Anders clarified.

“I take it you didn’t read his full history before our meeting,” Ms. Pips deduced. “My son has to be home-schooled because of his condition; the public school system declared him too dangerous to attend with the other children. Since I can’t take off every day to teach him, I hired a tutor. I’m not sure what he’s learning right now, but I trust the man’s teaching methods implicitly.”

“I see,” Ms. Anders said. “And, just to be clear, when you say condition...”

“Nick is a Powered. He has uncontrollable luck, good and bad. After the day he found a thousand dollars on the playground and was in the

bathroom when all of the toilets exploded due to a plumbing mishap, he was officially deemed unacceptable at any institution of learning,” Ms. Pips said matter-of-factly.

“Yes, of course. My apologies for bringing that up.” Ms. Anders was trying very hard to act less flustered than she was feeling. “Now, you’ve had Nick for nine years now, correct?”

“Ever since my sister and her husband had their car accident, lord rest her soul.”

“And in those years, how do you feel that Nick has developed, emotionally? I mean, living with a Vegas casino owner must be a unique childhood,” Ms. Anders said.

“Nick walks around every day with the knowledge that because of a fluke of birth he could die at any minute. A plane could fall from the sky, or a truck could hit him while he’s in the shower. He has to deal with his mortality in a much more real way than the rest of us ever have. I don’t think my son ever had a chance at an existence that wasn’t unique,” Ms. Pips answered.

“An excellent point,” Ms. Anders said. “That takes care of the preliminary work. I just wanted to introduce myself and get some initial information. As you know, in the next few weeks I’ll speak with you and Nick, both together and separately, just to make sure he’s adapting well to his environment.”

“I’m familiar with the process by this point,” Ms. Pips said with a surprisingly reassuring smile. “Though, to my knowledge, I’m also the only foster parent in this city with no complaints or reports who still receives yearly check-ups.”

“Standard procedure, I assure you,” Ms. Anders lied, gathering her notes and hastily rising from the table. “I’ll give you a call to set up another appointment.”

“I’ll look forward to it,” Ms. Pips replied, rising as well. “It was a pleasure meeting you, Ms. Anders. Enrique will escort you out.”

As if by magic, a muscular man stepped into view and waited patiently as Ms. Anders finished grabbing her things, then quietly followed her as she found the way to the door. Only after Enrique returned and confirmed that she was in her car and out of earshot did Ms. Pips make her way over to the blackjack table where the boy was sitting.

“So sorry, dear, but I have to speak with my dealer for a moment.

Please feel free to try your luck at another table, and tell them to get you something top shelf on me for the inconvenience,” Ms. Pips said to the woman still tossing away her cash in the vain hopes of getting twenty-one.

“‘S okay,” she slurred. “Needed to change anyway, got no luck at this table.” With that she stumbled away in search of another place to settle down and piss away time and funds.

“Okay, Nick,” Ms. Pips said as soon as the woman was gone, “what’s the count?”

“Deck’s almost done,” Nick replied, adjusting his glasses once more and double checking his numbers. “There should still be two threes, a four, two fives, three sevens, an eight, a nine, two jacks, and a king.”

“Gerry?” Ms. Pips asked.

“Spot on by my count,” said the large balding man in the suit.

“Good job,” Ms. Pips praised him. She then turned her attention on the dealer. “Tom, was he showing any tells you noticed?”

“He fiddles with his glasses when he’s adding and scratches the velvet with his right index finger when he’s mentally removing cards from what’s left in the deck,” Tom replied quickly.

“Nice observations, Tom,” Ms. Pips said. “Thanks for helping out today. Go ahead and get lunch at the restaurant on me.”

“Thank you, Ms. Pips,” the dealer said respectfully. He knew when he was being hustled off, and he had been at the casino long enough to know he should take the free lunch and get out of the way.

“Impressive,” Ms. Pips said, patting Nick on the head. “You tricked one of our better dealers with both fake tells, plus he didn’t even catch on that the glasses were fake.”

“They aren’t,” Nick replied.

Ms. Pips raised an eyebrow. “Excuse me?”

“They aren’t fake,” Nick repeated. “When Gerry took me to get some I realized that without a distortion it would be obvious to anyone observant that the lenses weren’t real. I knew that would bust me off the bat, so instead I had Gerry forge a prescription that would show distortion but wouldn’t mess up my near-sight so much that I couldn’t see that cards.”

“That true, Gerry?”

“Yes, ma’am,” Gerry replied. “Nick saw the hole in the plan and told me how he wanted it filled.”

“Ha!” Ms. Pips barked a laugh. “And here I thought Tom was losing his touch. That was smart, Nick, I didn’t think you’d find that one so easily.”

“You’ll have to do better next time,” Nick said with a genuine smile.

“And so will you, my little con man, so will you,” Ms. Pips said, smiling back. “Okay, Gerry, let’s get the glasses off of him before he damages his sight for real. After that, take him over to Fleece and have Nick work on his hand skills.”

“Um, Ms. Pips, I feel I would be remiss if I did not inform you that Fleece is set up over at The Bear Back this week,” Gerry brought up.

“So?” Ms. Pips asked.

“Given the mature nature of that club, I feel Nick might be too young to visit Fleece at that location,” Gerry said.

“He’s ten years old, Gerry, and it’s just a strip club. He nursed from tits when he was a baby, it’s not like they’ve changed a lot in the last decade,” Ms. Pips said.

“Yes, ma’am,” Gerry said obediently. His tenure and loyalty to Ms. Pips had earned him the right to bring possible problems and objections to her attention when it seemed necessary; Ms. Pips trusted he had the best interests of the family at heart. But no one had the right to argue back with her once she had laid down her decision.

“One more thing. Do some digging on our new CPS rep. I don’t think she’ll be much of a problem, but she’s got an idealistic streak in her and I’d rather be prepared,” Ms. Pips said.

“Yes, ma’am,” Gerry repeated.

“Okay, Nick, you work hard for Fleece today,” Ms. Pips said, turning her attention back to the boy.

“Yes, Ms. Pips,” Nick said respectfully.

“I’ll check with Fleece after. If you can get three solid pulls today, I’ll let Gerry do some work on misdirection with you later tonight.”

“Thank you, Ms. Pips,” Nick replied. He loved working with Gerry, and misdirection was one of his favorite subjects, so he knew he’d have to really try and get those pulls this afternoon.



“Be good,” Ms. Pips told him with a kiss on the cheek. “And always remember: luck is for tourists and losers.”

“Winners cheat,” she and Nick finished together in unison, as they had since she’d taught him the motto when he was first diagnosed as a Powered all those years ago.

\* \* \*

“I bet that power comes in really handy.”

“Hell yeah it does,” Nick replied. “Who knows how I’d get by without it?”

## 50.

“So, anything good going on this weekend?” Alex asked as he and Hershel sat down in the dining hall.

“Not that I’ve heard of. I think most people are freaking out about finals on the horizon and speculating on Tuesday’s mystery speaker,” Hershel replied.

“Yeah, that’s about what I’ve come up with, too. That sucks; usually there’s a video game tournament or some other dorm-sponsored event on any given weekend,” Alex complained, adjusting his tray to try and find a point of attack on the noodle surprise he had been served.

“Don’t you hate when class messes with college?” Hershel joked.

“That I do,” Alex said. “On the plus side, I heard there’s a big party going on next weekend held by one of the upperclassmen. Every Su... person in our class is invited.”

Hershel held his breath and tried to covertly scout the room to see if anyone was paying the pair attention. Not seeing any turned heads or huddled groups whispering, he decided to breeze over Alex’s almost fuck-up and hope no one had heard.

“Sounds fun,” Hershel said. “Nice of them to invite us freshmen.”

“Apparently it’s a tradition to let those of us who haven’t dropped out by this point participate. Plus, from what I’ve heard, our gym final is going to be brutal, so the experienced ones are showing us a bit more kindness,” Alex explained.

“No idea what that’s going to be yet, huh?” Hershel asked.

“No more than you. That’s a pretty tightly-guarded secret. The only thing I’ve been able to uncover is that it’s really intense.”

“That part I could have guessed,” Hershel commented. “Oh well, a party sounds fun. Roy’s been good lately, so it’ll be nice for him to blow off some steam.”

“Ah. So you’re going as Roy then?” Alex asked.

“Well, yeah; the parties are kind of his bread and butter,” Hershel said.

“No, I understand and all. It’s just that... well, I haven’t made a whole

lot of friends at Lander besides you, so I was kind of hoping I'd have someone there I already knew. And Roy is cool and all, but he and I don't get along quite the same," Alex said, working to avoid meeting Hershel's eyes as he spoke.

Hershel gave thought to his words before answering. He hadn't seen Alex really hang out with anyone besides him and his roommates, and given what he believed his power to be, it made a certain amount of sense. Most of the other Supers probably thought of him as idiotic or deranged.

"It might be nice to actually get to go out for once," Hershel said tentatively.

"You sure that's okay? I don't want to accidentally cause problems for you two."

"I'm not, but now that we've talked about it, Roy will remember the conversation next time he comes around and I can see how he feels about it. He's been really focused ever since his fight with Chad; he doesn't even go out too much anymore. I'd say there's a decent chance he'll let me have this one without objection, or at least agree to change halfway through," Hershel said.

"That'd be cool," Alex said.

"Yeah. You know, I think this would make the first party since I changed that I actually go as Hershel instead of Roy."

"Better hope it's a good one then," Alex chuckled.

"Better hope it's not too good, or Roy's gonna be pissed he missed," Hershel pointed out.

"Agreed. Then we will hope for a good party, but not a great one," Alex said, lifting his soda in toast.

"Here's to a lackluster but still entertaining party," Hershel said, lifting his own in suit. Glancing around, he realized while Alex's earlier comment may have passed unnoticed their impromptu toasting was definitely gathering a few odd stares from throughout the cafeteria.

Hershel felt less bothered by it than he would have expected.

## 51.

"Good afternoon, class," Dean Blaine greeted his students Tuesday morning, entering the already-full classroom with a slightly shorter, far more nervous man in tow. "I'm glad to see all of you could make it to listen to today's guest speaker. Your commitment to learning has been noted."

Nick was staring at the man who had come with Dean Blaine, clearly their guest speaker. He was twitchy, obviously uncomfortable with crowds, and his appearance was slightly unkempt. Nick could only guess what status this man must have to have garnered the podium away from Dean Blaine.

"Now, I'm sure you're all curious to hear from today's speaker, so I'll turn things over to him in just a moment. Before he begins, though, I would like you all to realize that this man has come as a personal favor, and I expect him to be treated with the same respect you would show to me. I'll consider anything less than that as a very personal offense," Dean Blaine spelled out clearly. "With that said, I give you Jacob Stuart."

The shorter man, Jacob, moved from behind Dean Blaine and took the dean's usual spot at the front of the room. He glanced around uncertainly and fiddled with his hands. After a few seconds of fumbling, Jacob took a deep breath and composed himself, then began to speak.

"As your dean said, my name is Jacob Stuart. What he didn't mention is that I'm a Powered."

To say a ripple of surprise went through the class would be like saying that fish are somewhat inclined towards water over land, when handed a choice. It was kept in check, though, and it became immediately clear exactly why Dean Blaine had put such emphasis on respecting their speaker.

"Your dean felt that you all would benefit from hearing about things from the perspective of someone who can't control their abilities," Jacob continued, blowing past the ripple of shock because... because, well, he had already been expecting it. "I think he is either an optimist to the point of idiocy or you must be the most open-minded class of Supers in the history of the world. From the looks on your faces, though, I'm sad to say it's seeming closer to the former than the latter."

Scowls and sneers were pulled up short as some Supers realized they were showing too much on their face. Nick continued a steady leer, not so angry as to draw attention but unhappy enough that anyone who glanced at him wouldn't mistake him as sympathetic to the plight of a Powered.

"My ability is teleportation, and it activates every time I sneeze," Jacob said. "I can't control where I go, or how far away I end from where I started out. I seem to have some natural sense of preservation, though, because I never teleport into an object or five miles up in the air. I'm always safe, just horribly inconvenienced. That's more or less all you need to know about me, so why don't we go ahead and let you ask any questions you might have? I'm sure most of you have never had occasion to talk to a Powered, after all."

"If you accidentally teleport when you sneeze, why don't you just teleport back afterward?" Stella blurted out in typical fashion.

"Because I can't," Jacob replied.

"But you just said you had the ability of teleportation," Stella kept probing.

"Yes, when I sneeze I teleport uncontrollably. And that's the only time I can do it. Unless I'm sneezing I can't teleport any more than I can turn lead in gold," Jacob explained.

"I get that you have the accidental thing," Stella continued. "I'm just asking why you never learned to use your power outside of the trigger so you could do it whenever you wanted."

"Let me ask you something, young lady, what's your power?" Jacob asked in response.

"I turn into steel."

"That sounds like a good one," Jacob complimented her. "But why don't you ever try flying instead?"

"Because that's not my power," Stella said slowly. "I told you, I turn into steel."

"And I told you, I teleport when I sneeze. I don't have the power to teleport at will any more than you have the power to fly. There's a common misconception that Powered's are too lazy or stupid to master our gifts, when the reality is that we just don't have that ability. Trust me, this isn't a lifestyle choice."

A well-manicured hand near the front raised slowly in the air.

"Yes?" Jacob said, gesturing to the girl asking the question.

"Do you hate Supers?" Alice asked. The class reacted visibly, and

Nick nearly fell out of his chair. What was that crazy bitch doing, drawing attention to herself in this kind of discussion? They needed to slide by and pray for class to end swiftly.

"I'm sorry, I think I misheard you," Jacob said.

"You didn't," Alice said. "I asked if you hated Supers. Your ability must make having any kind of normal life nearly impossible, yet when you look around there are people with all of the gift and none of the burden being idolized and worshiped by society. If not for a variant in your genetic coding, that might very well have been you. So do you hate us?"

"Of course I do," Jacob told her. "Every Powered hates Supers, and not just for the reasons you listed. While you are elite and special, we're looked at as a type of disabled person. We're considered lesser citizens, a social burden that people have to put up with. Most people think of us as nothing more than the price they pay for having Supers and Heroes. So of course I hate you, but not violently, just achingly. Aching for what might have been. I've got one for you now. Do you hate Powereds?"

"Of course I do," Alice echoed.

"And why is that?"

"Same reason. Because when I look at you, I see what might have been if not for a twist of fate," Alice elaborated.

"Wow," Jacob said. "You're a lot more honest with yourself than most Supers."

"Thank you," Alice accepted gracefully.

Another hand rose a few rows over from Alice, this one male.

"Is there any hope for your kind?" Chad asked without waiting to be called on.

"There's always hope, kid; if you take nothing else from this then please take that," Jacob answered. "No, there's no science, or miracle cure in the works that will make me more like you. No one has even been able to figure what the difference between Supers and Powereds is; as far as modern science can tell, we're genetically identical. So I'm not expecting some breaking news tomorrow announcing that we can become Supers, or even that we can just become human. But I have hope, because if I didn't, then I don't know how I would be able to keep pressing on. And besides, in a world where people can dance on the clouds, it isn't so crazy to hope for the impossible."

Chad accepted this explanation with a silent nod.

"Is it true no one knows what causes Poweredreds?" a dark-haired boy in the front called out.

"We don't even have a clue. Poweredreds can be born from Supers, regular humans, or other Poweredreds. The stats are across the board, and no one combination has been proven more likely," Jacob said.

"How did your parents take it?" Vince asked quietly. Nick made a note to whip up some cyanide punch and kill everyone he shared that damned dorm with. Two of them had called attention to themselves. Two!

"My parents?"

"Yeah. I mean, most parents are overjoyed to have a kid who is a Super. What's it like telling them that you're a Powered?" Vince elaborated.

"If you're able to tell them, then you're one of the lucky few," Jacob said. "Most of us get outed by the powers themselves. I sneezed myself right out of a birthday party when I was a kid. When I couldn't do it again by focusing my secret was pretty much out. As for how they took it... well, I was fortunate. They loved me and tried to be supportive of me. It was hard, though, because every time I came back after I vanished, I could see the disappointment they were hiding. Disappointed that they had almost sired greatness, but instead all they got was me. It's such a thin line between Powered and Super, yet that line may as well be a ravine from how separated we are."

Undoubtedly some students wanted to chime in with how they wished that line was bigger so they wouldn't have to talk to or deal with Poweredreds anymore. One didn't qualify for the HCP by being stupid, though, even if they could make it in despite ignorance. Dean Blaine had laid it clearly on the table before the talk began. This was constructive questions only: anything else would piss off the man who could boot them from the program with nothing more than a word.

"We won't be able to go on much longer," Dean Blaine interrupted from his seat. "Mr. Stuart has an engagement to which I have agreed to accompany him in fulfillment of our bargain. Let's take one more question and then you will be dismissed early."

Several hands went up this time, some last minute flurries of determination for the dean to see their participation and up the grade, others genuine probes of curiosity. Jacob scanned the crowd and selected one hand a few rows up.

"Okay, you in the sunglasses," Jacob announced, pointing up at Nick.

"Do you have any pepper?" Nick asked.

"Pepper?"

"Or a feather, or a thin line of cloth. Really anything along those lines," Nick said, half of him cursing himself for being the third Melbrook member to ask a question and half trusting in himself and his gambit.

Ever so slowly a smile crept across Jacob's face. He reached into his pants pocket and pulled out a long case. He popped it open and delicately removed a slender white feather. It was sturdy as well as slim and it looked very well cared for.

"Smart kid," Jacob commented.

"What the hell? How did he know you had a feather?" Stella blurted out.

"Because he's putting himself in my shoes," Jacob replied. "He's wondering, if he were in my situation, how would he use it to his advantage? And he came to the same conclusion as I did. You see, teleporting randomly can still be pretty useful for snapping yourself out of dangerous situations, and just because I can't make myself teleport doesn't mean I can't make myself sneeze."

"Crafty," Stella complimented.

"Dangerous," Nick corrected. "It's easy to get caught up in the pity party of what it must be like to be a Powered, but we're idiots if we forget that they aren't always helpless. Sometimes a power that can't be controlled is even more hazardous to fight than one that can be."

"Mr. Campbell," Dean Blaine cautioned, raising his voice in warning.

"No, it's okay," Jacob said. "The boy is right. You are a fool if you forget that the key word of Powered is power. We have it, even if it isn't reigned in, and some of us have stretched our resourcefulness to its limit for even a shred more of control. If you become Heroes you'll have to deal with Powered sometimes. Never underestimate them or make assumptions. Always be ready to ask yourself, if you had their condition, how would you try to utilize it? Sometimes answering that question will be the difference between winning and losing."

"On that note, I'd like to hear a round of applause to thank our guest for taking time out of his day to speak with us," Dean Blaine said. There was



a lukewarm sound of clapping that faded away quickly.

"You can take your time in going to gym," Dean Blaine said as the last lone clapper gave up the fight. "The coaches won't be expecting you until your regular time. I thought you might like to take these extra minutes and talk amongst yourselves about what we covered today. That is your choice, though; just be at gym when the hour arrives." With that, he and Jacob exited the room, and after a minute or two of waiting to make sure he wouldn't come back, the rest of the class began flowing toward the door as well.

Nick gathered up his own things and sighed inwardly. He'd managed to diffuse a lot of the sympathy the class had been building toward Jacob, and in doing so had marked himself as someone with no compassion for Powered's. It was a bit paranoid, admittedly, to worry that someone would make such a leap from Melbrook students being sympathetic toward Powered's to suspecting they had once been Powered's themselves, but Nick often thought of paranoia as nothing more than extreme preparedness. He had done what he had to do, even if it was built on a very unlikely fear. Unlikely was something you learned to account for when you grew up with bipolar luck, though, so Nick reaffirmed that it was necessary to shift the pity toward Jacob partially into suspicion and fear.

Knowing all that, he still felt a sense of guilt rising in his stomach. That, at least, he knew exactly how to deal with though.

## 52.

“What. The Fuck. Was that?” These were the words that greeted Dean Blaine as he returned to his office some hours after the class and his errand with Jacob had been finished.

“Mr. Campbell,” Dean Blaine said graciously. “My secretary informed me you’d been waiting in my office for some time. I must say I’m impressed at your patience.”

Nick stared back at him stonily. There might have been some emotion in the eyes hidden away by those sunglasses, but the face was an absolute blank. No feeling, no sentiment, no expectation, only an unending resolve in waiting for his answer.

“Fine, then. ‘That’, as you put it, was my attempt to develop some semblance of humane feelings towards Powered in my class,” Dean Blaine said.

“Have you ever done it before?” Nick asked.

“Well, no,” Dean Blaine admitted.

“Then why in God’s sweet name would you do it this time?” Nick asked, rising to his feet.

“Because it’s more relevant,” Dean Blaine replied.

“No, it isn’t,” Nick corrected him. “There is no relevance to it at all. Powered are broken products, lesser Supers, a group with an unfortunate disability, and not one person in that class needs to think any differently. We’re all Supers after all, so who is going to get offended?”

“Mr. Campbell, if you’re afraid that my experiment will compromise your secret, I can assure you-”

“Stop,” Nick said, holding up his hand. The gesture was unnecessary: the tone of his voice alone would have frozen water. “Do you fully understand how tenuous our position here is? Do you realize what a ridiculous stroke of luck it is that the only real telepath in our class is one of us? Do you think for one moment you really understand what it will be like if our secret gets out? Let me assure you of something, Dean Blaine. I’m certain your heart is in the right place, but don’t you ever fucking dare believe for an instant you know what it’s like growing up as a Powered. Until you’ve seen the looks of disgust and disappointment on people’s faces, until you’ve been literally terrified out

of your mind about what you'll cause to happen next, and until you've seen that same fear of the eyes of those you love, only then you can talk to me about how you're doing your best to keep our secret."

"Feel better?" Dean Blaine asked. "That was quite the little monologue."

"It needed to be said," Nick replied. "You're too careless, and I understand today was about trying to help us, but honestly, the best thing you can do to help us is treat us like everyone else."

"In that case I should probably kick you out since you've sworn at the dean of your program twice in last few minutes," Dean Blaine said.

"Do what you've got to do," Nick shot back. "Just understand that while Mary and Roy, and maybe even Vince, could still hang on if we got outed, Alice and I wouldn't last a week. We're not the combat type; the only thing that lets us fly through here is being part of the community of Supers. If we were targeted, or different, there's no way we'd be able to hold on."

"I take it that's why you consistently make grades at almost exactly the median of the class," Dean Blaine speculated.

"On my best day it's still tenuous that my power should have gotten me in here," Nick said. "Not making waves is the best strategy I've got."

"Very well, Mr. Campbell," Dean Blaine said. "I'll take what you've said under advisement for my future lessons. I'll do this because this is the first time you've actually talked to me as yourself, the bright observant boy we both know you to be, rather than that insipid character you've concocted."

"It made more sense to abandon the pretense, otherwise I couldn't have had this discussion with you," Nick confessed.

"A wise choice, though I'm sure you'll be playing the same part in our future classroom interactions," Dean Blaine said.

"Of course," Nick confirmed.

"I can accept that. I do hope you realize my door is always open to you, though, not just when you wish to go on a tirade. Since you've already shown your true self to me, there's no harm in dropping by to talk. If you would like," Dean Blaine offered.

"I'll keep that in mind."

"Good. I think we're done then, Mr. Campbell, unless there was

anything else?”

“No, as long as there are no more stunts like today, we should be fine,” Nick said, turning to go.

“Oh, and I should point out there were two problems with your argument,” Dean Blaine said. “Firstly, Ms. Smith is not the only telepath in your year, as you should know from having met Mr. Griffen.”

“Alex is a nice guy, but he’s closer to an empath than a telepath. He rarely gets thoughts, mostly emotions,” Nick said.

“As far as you know,” Dean Blaine pointed out. “It would be wise not to underestimate anyone who has made it into my program. That brings up the second problem. Your ‘tenuous power’, as you described it, is not what elevated you into the HCP.”

“Oh?” Nick asked without turning around. He was confident his face was still controlled, but there was no reason to risk giving anything away when it was avoidable.

“Indeed. The power qualifies you as a Super, but in your evaluation it was your intelligence and strategic thinking that made you Hero material,” Dean Blaine said.

“Good to know,” Nick said, walking to the door and swiftly exiting the dean’s office. Somewhere in course of that conversation he’d lost his power and momentum, but he’d gained insight into how the dean worked, and that might prove to be invaluable. Aside from that, he’d gotten a slight idea at what Dean Blaine’s power might be, and that information he *knew* would be useful. Now he just had to think of a way to test his hypothesis.

After finals, though. Even Nick wasn’t confident enough to try and take on more projects before the semester ended.

## 53.

"I'm glad you talked us into coming out," Hershel told Alex as they entered the living room of a two-story house. The couches were wrapped in plastic and it seemed someone had laid a blue tarp down on top of most of the carpet. The house was full, though not bursting like the other clubs and parties they had been to. It was loud enough to see that people were having fun, though it hadn't crossed the line into utter pandemonium yet.

"I think we all needed it after that bummer of a presentation on Tuesday," Alex said. "I mean, I agree with what Dean Blaine was trying to do, but he should have known most people weren't ever going to be sympathetic toward some Powered."

"You are," Vince pointed out.

Alex shrugged. "Nearly everyone thinks I'm crazy or delusional. It's hard for me to get up on my high horse about how I'm so much better than someone else. Besides, that's not the Jedi way."

"The Jedi had better get out of my way," Nick said, shouldering into the room. He and Alice were the last of the group, Mary having opted to stay in and the rest of their friends studying for finals already. In truth, Nick was tempted to use the same excuse; however, after letting himself go and tearing into Dean Blaine, he felt like he needed to recenter his character. Sadly, a social environment full of Supers was the best place for that.

"Welcome, Fish," said a tall blonde girl holding a red plastic cup. She and Alice had a slight similarity, in the way that a dog and wolf can look the same if one isn't paying attention. She wasn't imposing, per se, but the way she walked, smiled, and ever tossed her hair left no doubt in anyone's mind that this woman was a warrior. "I'm glad you guys made it out. My name is Angela and this is my house."

"Thank you for inviting us," Vince said politely.

"No worries, it's a tradition to invite those of you who last this long to join us. It's our way of saying good job on getting this far, and that we're welcoming you into the Super community at Lander," Angela replied.

"So this party is all Supers?" Alex asked.

"You got it," Angela confirmed. "Feel free to let down your hair and be yourself. Tonight your secret identity is safe with us."

"We really appreciate it," Alice said, using all of her willpower not to curtsy. She had begun rapidly realizing that the stiff formality she had learned at Daddy's functions were not suited to the college environment. Plus, she was wearing slacks, so she would have looked ridiculous.

"Like I said, no big deal," Angela assured. "Besides, you had the balls to come. That means you belong here. You'd be amazed how many people who are here to learn about fighting life and death battles are too squeamish to come out to a party with older students."

"That and it is the beginning of finals time," Hershel pointed out.

"Which is why this also shows us who the irresponsible crowd is," Angela said with a wink. "Anyway, the keg is the garage and we have some liquor on the counter. Help yourself to whatever you want; buying for the freshmen is also part of the tradition."

"Um, we're under age," Vince said.

"As am I, as are most of us here, in fact. I recommend you enjoy it while you can, though. Apparently once you hit junior year there isn't any time for a beer or a party," Angela said. "Your call, though: drink or don't, but mingle and have some fun either way." With that, Angela sauntered back off into the shapeless blob of people.

"Sasha's going to be pissed she missed a chance to be irresponsible," Vince commented once she was gone.

"So's Roy," Hershel added.

"Think he'll want to come out?" Alex asked.

"Absolutely. Now ask me if I care," Hershel said with a sideways grin. "Come on, guys, let's mingle."

A bit surprised at being led by the most socially awkward of the group, everyone followed Hershel as he led them into the kitchen where most people were gathered. Given that the kitchen was where the liquor was kept, as well as the cups, not to mention that it was only a door away from the keg in the garage, it was the logical gathering place for the attendees. What seemed illogical, though, was the ease with which Hershel was navigating them through it. He was greeting people, shaking hands, getting names, and moving onward. It was oddly mind-blowing, though it shouldn't have been. After all, Hershel was a role-player, and with Roy's memories this was a role he knew by heart. If the others were surprised by his rapport with the older students, they were flabbergasted when Hershel finally reached the cups and

plucked a few from the top.

"What does everybody want?" Hershel asked, turning his attention to the liquor selection.

"Are you serious?" Vince asked in a nearly strangled voice. "You know we can't drink."

"No, I know that we legally shouldn't drink. I also know that since I didn't drive here, I feel like seeing what it's like firsthand for once, and it seems like these first two years are going to be the only chance we'll get. More importantly, I don't want to go through college with my alter ego as the only one doing stupid crap and trying new things," Hershel said, not without conviction. He didn't feel quite as certain as he sounded, but he was determined to make some memories of his own. His talk with Alex had made him realize how easily he defaulted to letting Roy be the one to go party or chase the girl. This was his life too, damn it.

"Spoken like a man after my own heart," Nick said, stepping to Hershel's side. "Let me try... the gin."

"And?" Hershel asked.

"Um... ice?"

"You want straight gin for your first taste of alcohol," Hershel said incredulously.

"I thought that's how you were supposed to take it," Nick lied.

"Never mind, I'll make you something myself. Roy's tried tons of drinks," Hershel said, waving off Nick. "Anyone else?"

Alice cautiously raised her hand and Alex joined more enthusiastically.

"Guess that makes me the designated driver," Vince grumbled.

"Aw, cheer up, Silver," Nick consoled him. "At least you can see things better than us from up on your moral high ground."

"I'm not on the high ground. I get why you guys want to try it. That's just not my thing," Vince defended.

"Well, bottoms up to Vince for being our reliable driver then," Nick said, accepting a drink from Hershel and toasting with it. He took a sip and was pleasantly surprised. Nick had been drinking since childhood and actually did prefer straight gin, but for a mixed drink Hershel's concoction was pretty

good. The smiles and smacks of the rest of the group confirmed his opinion.

"That's tasty, Hershel," Alice complimented. "All I've had is wine with dinner once or twice, and this is way better."

"I do what I can," Hershel modestly.

"What are you drinking?" Alex asked, noting Hershel's liquid was a different color.

"Screwdriver," Hershel replied. "Your drinks have whiskey in them, and I don't drink whiskey."

"Much as I love your same old faces, let's get out of this corner and go get our mingle on," Nick said, gesturing grandly. He began wading back into the crowd, the others following with far less grandeur. Not without any, mind you; just with less.



## 54.

Walking around the party was a somewhat surreal experience. Sure, it was a new environment to most of them, but that in itself wasn't overpowering. The odd part was just how normal everything seemed... until it didn't. Seeing a guy talking to a hot girl at a party: normal. Seeing that same guy produce a rose made of perfect glass from nowhere: significantly less normal. It wasn't the extraordinary parts that seemed out of place, it was seeing them used so casually in a place like this. Slowly it was dawning on the Lander freshmen just how paranoid the secret identity had made them over the semester. Hiding their nature was hardly a new experience for some, but it struck Alice that she hadn't gone flying since she first learned she was able to. Sure, she'd used it here and there in training, that wasn't the same thing as soaring above world, though. Alex, too, was missing the days when he didn't have to keep his nature hidden away under lock and key.

As the group maneuvered the party, they saw mostly unfamiliar faces. Occasionally a member would recognize a sophomore that they'd seen in the hall a few times; however, that can hardly be considered the same as seeing a friend. Gradually, though, more small huddled groups of freshmen joined the party. They moved in packs, unconsciously fearful that they would be picked off should they separate from the herd. Such fears seemed baseless, as all the older students went out of their way to show kindness and a welcoming attitude to the freshmen. Still, the small groups maintained their tight formations.

It was in one other such group that Vince finally saw someone he knew outside of his own social circle.

"Hey!" Vince called out. "Thomas, right?"

"Right," Thomas answered, leading his own small circle toward Vince's. Smacked over the head with a sudden realization of potential unwanted conversation topics, Vince detached himself from his friends and intercepted Thomas on the premise of a friendly handshake.

"Didn't expect to see you here," Vince said with a large smile, squeezing and pumping Thomas' hand.

"Ditto," Thomas echoed. "I thought you'd have had your fill of parties."

"Eh heh. No, you know me, social butterfly. So who are your friends?" Vince asked hastily.

"Oh, well, this is Stella and Violet," Thomas said, taking a step to the side and indicating to each girl in turn. Vince already knew Stella on sight, but Violet turned out to be an almost unremarkable girl from their class. Average height, cute without being eye-catching, but with hair dyed a shade of purple so deep it was almost black (hence the almost quantifier).

"Nice to meet you both," Vince said, resisting the urge to look over his shoulder and see if the others were still hovering in the area. "I never got a chance to say it in person, but thank you again."

"No prob," Stella quipped. "So you don't want your buddies to know you got your ass kicked, huh?"

"Beg pardon?" Vince nearly choked on his words.

"What Stella is trying to say is that it's clear you wanted to greet us before this conversation was in earshot of your friends, and we'll of course respect your wish for privacy," Violet said, a lilting and slightly high-pitched voice piping out of her.

"Oh um... yes," Vince admitted. "I appreciate what you did, but I haven't really told them about what happened."

"There is no shame in what happened to you," Thomas assured him. "We will, as Violet said, of course respect your wishes."

"Sort of a moot point anyway. Looks like they wandered off," Stella pointed out.

"Huh," Vince noticed. "That they did."

"Well, now we get to talk to you outside of a combat situation, so all the better for us," Violet said cheerfully.

"Thank you," Vince said again, unsure of how to respond to such a statement. An honest thought and change of subject both occurred to him at once. "Wasn't there someone else with you that night?"

"Oh, that was my roommate, Camille," Violet explained. "She's not big on parties. I pretty much had to drag her out of the house that night."

"Too bad, I would have liked to thank her in person," Vince said.

"Do it Monday then," Stella said. "In the meantime, how about showing us where the beer in this joint is?"

\* \* \*

"Why are we leaving Vince?" Alex asked as Nick herded the group away after a minute or so of standing around.

"Because it's a party, and the point is to meet new people, not feel guilty into sticking with the ones you already know," Nick explained.

"Still, it seems like we should have said something," Alex objected again.

"I'm actually with Nick on this one," Hershel agreed. "He was mingling with new people. Us hanging around wasn't going to help him with that. Besides, it's a small house, he can find us when he's ready. In the meantime, we can do some mingling of our own, and I think I see the perfect opportunity now." Hershel picked up his pace, leading the others to a ping pong table on which cups were being arranged in a triangular formation and beer was being poured into them.

"Anyone got next game?" Hershel asked.

"Nah," replied a tall boy with black hair who was setting up the cups on one side. "You want in?"

"Sure," Hershel replied. He turned back to look at the others. "Who wants to play with me?"

"I'll watch and learn the game first," Alice said.

"Still working on my first drink. I'm out," Alex said.

"Guess that leaves me," Nick shrugged, stepping up and taking his place on one side of the table.

The other team took their place, and the dark-haired boy laid down the rules. "One bounce is allowed: anymore and you can smack it away. Distractions and trash talk are fine as long as you don't touch the ball. Game can't be won until one team misses and another scores in the same round, so if we keep scoring, neither cup gets removed. Powers are fair game."

Nick raised an eyebrow. "You sure about that?"

"Totally," the boy confirmed. "It makes these games a lot more fun. Besides, how often do we get to just let go and use them? They're only allowed on your turn, though, and no deflecting with it unless your opponent has bounced more than once."

"Fair enough," Hershel agreed. "I'm Hershel and this is Nick."

"Ben and Chris," said the dark-haired boy, gesturing first to himself,

then to his darker-skinned companion. "You need a warm-up round?"

"Nah," Hershel said. "Let's do this."

## 55.

"So how do you guys know each other?" Vince asked once the ladies had gotten their cups and beer to fill them. Thomas, like Vince, had found the idea of drinking underage not becoming of one reaching for the goal of being a Hero.

"Thomas and I dated for a bit in the first month," Violet said. "It didn't work out too well, but we stayed friends. I met Stella at the gym one day when I was looking for a sparring partner. We gave each other a good workout and decided to do it again the next day. We kept fighting, and somewhere along the way started doing stuff outside of beating each other senseless."

"Wow," Vince said. "So you must be pretty tough if you can fight someone who can turn into solid steel."

"Sort of," Violet admitted, blushing slightly. "I manipulate density. So I can make myself denser than titanium, or so insubstantial that I pass through walls. I can do it in objects, too. That's how I weakened the ice and popped you out that night."

"She's a handful when you get her in the fighting mood," Stella complimented. "She's only one rank behind me at three."

"Impressive," Vince agreed. "And Thomas, you have some sort of energy beams? I saw them when you grabbed Michael."

"Essentially," Thomas nodded. "I command my inner energy outward of my body. It shapes according to my will, though the dimensions are limited by the amount I can summon. In my time at Lander it has grown significantly stronger, though."

"Really? Just from body-breaking exercise?" Vince asked.

"The exercise certainly helps, but I attribute it more to the constant training I do in my off time. Having a variety of skilled opponents forced me to learn to new styles of fighting, and that helped me grow as a warrior subsequently," Thomas explained.

"I see," Vince said. "So it sounds like you spend a lot of time training outside of class."

"We all do," Violet chirped in. "Everyone higher up says it's crazy easy to go from the top to the bottom in your first year if you don't work

hard."

"It is especially important in cases like my own," Thomas pointed out. "I am ranked as seven, but my power could easily be viewed as ancillary, more useful as support than combat. I have to work very hard to demonstrate otherwise."

"You've got a leg up on me," Vince said with a smile he didn't feel. "I'm only at eight."

"I'd heard about how you were ranked that high after losing your first bout. You must have put on a hell of a show," Thomas said.

"He took on that douche we pulled off of him. Guess that counts for something," Stella said.

"Not to mention Michael is the worst type of opponent for me," Vince said, only half-defensively. This whole line of conversation was making him realize just how little effort he was putting in compared to some of the other students. He'd been avoiding additional conflict for fear of having to charge up his powers more. That might be a reality he'd have to face sooner than expected if he wanted to keep up with people this determined, though.

"Why is he your worst type?" Violet asked.

"I absorb energy," Vince explained. "Michael's power is cold-based. Cold is literally the absence of energy, so he can come at me all day and I can't absorb anything he throws."

"Cool power, though," Stella said. "What all can you absorb?"

"Oh you know, just the basics," Vince deflected. "Hey what's going on over there?"

\* \* \*

What was going on over there was a surprisingly close battle of beer pong with both teams down to a single cup. As it turned out, Ben was a shifter like Hershel, so his powers were out of commission until he decided to make the change. So far he was doing well enough in normal form. Hershel was keeping up decently, but it was really Nick and Chris that were the juggernauts of the game. Chris, it turned out, had the power to teleport objects he touched. This made his style of play less bouncing based and more just teleporting directly over the cup he wanted. That should have sealed the game, save only for the Nick factor.

With his honed dexterity and power over luck, Nick was tearing up the

table on par with his opponent. Sure he should have been laying low, squeezing by without drawing attention, staying in the middle ground, but damn it, this was fun! He'd been in such a secondary position at Lander, so accustomed to the idea that everyone around him was better at everything. They were stronger, they were faster, even a few of them were smarter. For the first time in months though he was doing something he could win at. It felt good to be a winner; it reminded of who he really was under his ridiculous facade. Besides, it wasn't like people didn't already know what his power was. It would have been more suspicious if he hadn't been running the table. At least, that's what he told himself as he dunked yet another ball into a red cup.

"Fucker," Ben swore, chugging down the contents.

"You're good, Sunglasses. You're real good," Chris told him, picking up the ball for his turn. "But me, I don't miss." The ball vanished from Chris's hand and reappeared a few inches over one of the remaining cups on Hershel and Nick's side.

Nick threw Hershel a glance and the heavier boy took the cup and guzzled. He was beginning to feel all the alcohol, and far sooner than he'd expected. Roy always had such insane tolerance that Hershel had forgotten somewhere along the way that it didn't extend to him. He needed to finish this game soon if they were going to have a chance.

"Come on, Hershel!" Alice cheered in spite of herself. "Sink it to keep the pressure on."

Hershel drew in a breath and took his aim. He released the ball, and it flew almost true. As it landed for its first bounce it veered ever so slightly off course, sending it into the cup's rim instead of the bitter beer inside.

"Oooh, so sorry there, freshman," Ben taunted. "Looks like you just don't know how to push through in the clutch. Don't worry, though, that comes with experience." On the word "experience" Ben tossed his own ball. It arced gracefully through the air, hopping once and depositing itself in the lone remaining cup in front of Nick. Without a second glance Nick scooped up the red cup of failure and did his duty.

"Ah well; win some, lose some," Hershel said, trying to stay steady in spite of a slowly mounting urge to slur.

"You fought a good game," Ben said sportingly. "Chris and I haven't had anyone go that long with us in a long time. Up for another?"

"Not sure about Nick, but I'm going to pass," Hershel replied.

"I can keep going," Nick said with a smile. Unlike Hershel, Nick had earned his tolerance for alcohol the hard way and was nowhere near hitting his limits.

"Sad to see you go, big boy," Chris said. "You were the weak link in the team anyway."

"Dude," Ben snapped at his friend. "Be nice."

"Fuck you, I've never been on board with this 'coddle the freshmen' idea," Chris shot back.

"It's fine," Hershel said with a grin. "I was the weak link. It's true, so how bad could it be that he said it?"

"I'm sorry," Ben apologized. "My friend can be an asshole when he's competing and drinking."

"Like I said, it's fine," Hershel shrugged.

"Yeah, Ben, it's fine. He knows he can't drink. Next game, I say we take on the broad and the pussy who wanted to watch," Chris said with a snicker.

"Hey!" This was actually snapped by Alice, Alex, and Nick simultaneously. In addition to yelling, Alex was searching for something not too property damaging to throw at Chris. Alice, unfortunately, lacked such means of recourse, but was unhappy nonetheless. Before any of them could take any action, though, Hershel acted first. He held up his right hand in a swift, stopping motion honed from years of commanding troops. Elf troops battling an orc invasion admittedly, but command skills were command skills, regardless of the venue in which they were acquired.

"Alex," Hershel said in an oddly still voice. "May I have your drink, please?"

"Um, sure," Alex said, handing Hershel his cup and the remaining liquid inside.

"Thank you," Hershel replied, swallowing the last of it in one gulp. He handed the cup back to Alex and walked back over to the table.

"I thought you didn't drink whiskey," Alex commented.

"He doesn't," came a deeper, rougher voice from Hershel's throat. A slow ripple seemed to move across Hershel's body, giving him an amorphous appearance. His torso and limbs lengthened, muscles emerged where only fat



had been, and his face became leaner and more chiseled. It happened in the matter of seconds, and then someone totally different was standing where Hershel had been.

"I do," said Roy, his eyes hard and a smile that seemed more dangerous than joyful slicing across his face. "Now I'm going to show you what happens to the poor bastards who question the drinking skills of a Daniels man."

## 56.

Roy had changed the game, and not in a figurative sense.

"Whiskey," Roy reiterated.

"Excuse me?" Ben asked, trying to understand.

"Your boy called me out, so I'm upping the stakes. We play with half cups of whiskey instead of beer, unless you girls think you can handle full ones," Roy replied. Mary might bitch him out for being condescending, but given the circumstances he was confident he could talk his way out of too much earache.

"Half is fine," Chris said, answering for his partner. "Mind if Ben changes first?"

"Be my guest," Roy replied with a generous smile. Ben's features melded together, his skin becoming scaly and thick while his hair retreated into his head. His pupils became vertical slits and small, dagger-like claws grew out from his hand. "Snakeman?" Roy asked when Ben's transformation was done.

"Closer to lizard, actually," Ben corrected with a shrug. His voice sounded a bit more like sandpaper rubbing together than it had before, but there weren't any of the drawn out S sounds that one might have expected from his appearance.

"Hope that form comes with improved aim," Roy said.

Ben grinned, an act which had become several degrees more disturbing. "It does."

"Good. You won last game, so you shoot first once the cups are filled," Roy said.

"Agreed," Chris said. "We'll get the whiskey."

"Fine by me," Roy said. Once the two had ventured off to the kitchen though, Roy immediately turned his attention on Nick. "Please, please, please tell me you can at least halfway hold your liquor."

\* \* \*

"This took an interesting turn somewhere," Vince said as he sidled up to Alice and Alex, joining in the slowly-growing crowd watching the cups be

filled.

"I feel like we should have expected it somehow," Alex replied. "So, who are your friends?"

"Oh, right," Vince said, reddening at his blunder. A quick round of introductions later and everyone was gathered to observe the beginning of the rematch.

"So I get Roy doing this, but why is Nick going along with it?" Alice wondered aloud.

"Because it's fun," Alex answered automatically. The other threw him a speculative look, so he clarified. "I sense thoughts and emotions too, remember? Just because I don't pick up with the clarity of Mary doesn't mean I can't feel the waves of enjoyment flooding off of Nick."

"He does love being the center of attention," Vince pointed out.

"No, the kid who wears sunglasses all the time likes people looking at him? I never would have put that one together," Stella snickered.

"Hush, you," Violet chided her. "It can't be easy to have a power like luck. I mean, how are you even sure when it's working or if it's just coincidence? That has to make it difficult staying afloat in the HCP."

"Knowing Nick, I think he just assumes everything good is his power at work," Alice said.

"Knowing Nick, I'm not so sure that it isn't," Vince countered.

Alice opened her mouth to say otherwise, then thought better of it. "I hope luck powers come packaged with a new liver or the ability to turn alcohol into water, otherwise we'll be carting him out of here if they lose."

"I guess that means we're hoping they win," Alex said.

"Of course," Vince said automatically.

"Then shut up and cheer because they're starting."

\* \* \*

Roy's powers didn't actually make him any better at beer pong than Hershel. Sure, his senses were a little sharper, and of course he had strength and endurance far beyond the human threshold; however, none of that made bouncing a Ping-Pong ball into a cup an easier task. What did help, though, was a wealth of experience playing drinking games, a nearly endless alcohol

tolerance, and more confidence than a rooster in a hen house.

"Suck it," Roy called as the ball left his hand, hurtling through the air and landing deftly in one of the few remaining cups on the other side of the table. Chris's hand hesitantly picked up said cup, removed the ball, and choked down the contents. He and Ben were veteran beer pong players, using his power and Ben's skill to triumph over nearly every opponent. Since they usually won, though, they had to drink less, and as they worked their way through an ocean of whiskey it had begun to dawn on the duo that this had a significant disadvantage at times. Ben was holding up well thanks to his own enhanced endurance, but Chris's awareness and focus were deteriorating by the minute.

"Your shot," Nick said cheerily. Chris nodded in acknowledgment and took several deep breaths. He cleared his mind and held the ball firmly. His eyes locked on the area over one of the remaining cups on Nick and Roy's side, and with a burst of energy the ball snapped out of his hand in a puff of smoke. It reappeared almost instantaneously, dropping straight down toward the cup. Chris's aim had been off though, and the ball struck the cup's rim rather than the brown liquid below. It took a bad hop and struck the table once before landing on the carpet.

"And that's the game," Roy announced, plucking the ball from the ground and dousing it in a cup of water.

"You think you've won just because I missed once?" Chris challenged.

"I know we've won because you've hit the point where you can't focus properly. Ben is good, but not good enough to take on both of us, and my money says you've always used your power so you don't have any real skills at this game," Roy explained.

"I'm fine," Chris spit back defiantly. "I just slipped."

"Right, and as more alcohol is digested and enters the blood stream, you're going to find it easier to teleport things precisely," Nick said. "Never thought I'd say this, but Roy is right. Out of respect for your partner we'll let you take the remaining cups and walk away from the game so you don't have to slam them down."

"Fuck you, take your shot," Chris replied.

"Now hold on, man," Ben said, butting in. "I'm not staying in shifted form all night, and when I go back there will still be a lot of alcohol in my system to process. They're actually being nice and letting us call it here, so I say we take them up on it. They upped the stakes and played better, no big

deal. It's just a stupid game of beer pong."

"I am not giving up," Chris said. "And I am not losing to a damn freshman."

"So be it," Nick said, shrugging. He took the ball from Roy and tossed it casually into the air. It sailed effortlessly into one of the remaining three cups.

"I'm not drinking anymore," Ben declared as Chris's eyes fell on him. "I told you I wanted to be done."

"Fine, I'll do it myself then," Chris countered, snagging the cup and forcing it all down in one swallow. "Your shot," he said, wiping his mouth and handing the ball to Ben. In response Ben's skin grew pink as he shifted back to his regular form.

"I told you, I'm out. And you should be, too; you're going to be sick as a dog."

"Who gives a shit?" Chris said, weaving his body back to facing the table.

"Me." The voice that made that declaration was very calm, very relaxed, and contained not so much as an iota of threat in its tone. At the same time, everyone in range discerned a simple truth from that voice, something that radiated down and registered on a primal level.

The owner of that voice was not to be fucked with.

"Now Chris," Angela continued, walking up to him as the crowd parted before her. "We know that you're an asshole, but you're our asshole. We put up with your crap out of love and camaraderie. I'm going to be feeling a lot less love if you start throwing up in my house."

Chris's gaze locked on the tall girl in front of him. She was smiling placidly and had open, caring body language. Physically she seemed the opposite of daunting. It was more like a gentle kitten asking a favor. Chris had been in class with her for a year and a half, though. He was intoxicated and rapidly getting worse. He wasn't drunk enough to make the mistake of crossing her, though. It was hard to imagine the poor bastard who ever had been that drunk.

"Good game, guys," Chris said, stumbling away from the table. "Sorry I got a little too competitive there."

"No problem," Nick said graciously.

"Come again anytime," Roy sniped as Ben led Chris away, presumably to the bushes or an unoccupied toilet to try and forcibly reduce the amount of alcohol assaulting his system.

"Now, as for you two," Angela said, turning her attention to the winners. "Nice game. Try to keep the pissing matches to a minimum in the future, though. If someone gets angry and a fight starts, all of our identities are in danger. Not to mention two Supers can tear up a house in no time flat."

"My apologies," Nick said. "Things got a bit out of hand and our drive to win got the better of us."

"You're fine, Chris's liver will recover, and you provided some excellent entertainment. I'm just saying be careful who you challenge around here. Looks can be very deceiving."

Roy and Nick nodded agreement, and if Mary were there she would have heard all four of her other dorm mates sharing almost the exact same though simultaneously. There were variations of course, with Roy's being a bit more racy and Vince's leaning more toward a guilty self-admission, but the overall wording was inherently similar:

"Lady, you don't know the half of it."

\* \* \*

"Surely there must be something more interesting to do on a Saturday night than playing chess," Mr. Numbers commented while Mary was pondering her next move.

"Nah, I'm not much of a party girl. Besides, they can't into that much trouble without me," she said.

## 57.

The days on the Lander campus slipped by and finals season went into full swing. Students in the HCP were expected to maintain at least a C average in their normal courses, so even though many would have preferred to let schoolwork fall by the wayside, the Super community found itself stressed out and studying hard. Adding to the anxiety of the freshman class was fear of the unknown, manifesting in terror and rumors regarding their end of semester exam in gym. Coach George had announced it would take place on December 17, the day after all normal finals were wrapped. Anyone who didn't show up was assumed to be dropping out of the program. Different students were dealing with this looming challenge in different ways. Some were hoarding information, rumor-mongering in a desperate attempt to find anything that would give them an edge. Others were throwing themselves into their other classes, working hard in a sort of cosmic trade-out for the class they wished they could be preparing for. Some, though, had altogether unique coping methods entirely.

"I really don't see how having a *Quantum Leap* marathon is an appropriate way to spend the last Saturday we have for studying," Vince said as Nick rearranged the furniture to allow for more viewers.

"I still have a math final. Isn't quantum a mathy word?"

"Seriously, Nick."

"Look, people need to chill out today," Nick explained. "Research shows that relaxed people test better than stressed out ones. I'm offering that opportunity in the form of classic sci-fi television. No one is making you partake in it."

"Except that you commandeered the boy's lounge," Vince pointed out.

"You've got a room and a library left," Nick countered. "Though you more than any of us could use a day to do nothing. You're worrying so much I think your hair has started to shift in hue from silver to white."

"Funny," Vince said. "How can you be so calm about all this? In four days we have to take our semester final for gym, a test that's going to determine if we're still in the program after Christmas, and no one has any idea what it entails."

"Oh, plenty of people know what it is, they just aren't telling us freshmen. I can only assume it's what constitutes hazing around here."

Psychological torture, if you will,” Nick said. “Besides, every test we take will be determining if we’re still in the program. Better to learn how to go with the flow now and save yourself from an ulcer by the time we’re juniors.”

“We could be spending this time studying for our other tests at least,” Vince said.

“Buddy, this whole last month has been almost nothing but study group and reviews. I don’t know about you, but I am burned out. Me rereading the same crap today isn’t going to do a lick of good. Spending some time with my friends, though, that one might have some positive effects. Given the two choices, I’m going with the one that involves time travel and popcorn,” Nick said.

Vince laughed a bit in spite of himself. “I don’t know how you do it, Nick. You’re the only person here who can just roll through things so carefree. I’m seriously beginning to believe that’s your actual power.”

“Just an easygoing guy, I guess,” Nick lied. “Let things fall where they may and do the best you can. Take our gym final, for example. Sure, I don’t know what’s coming, but neither did any other class before me and they still seem to have students graduating.”

“Far fewer than we do currently, though,” Vince said.

“So maybe this will weed out a few more of ours. And maybe I’ll be one of them. If I thought spending the day holed up in my room agonizing over the possibilities would help then I’d... no, even then I still probably wouldn’t do it. That’s beside the point, though, since it doesn’t help,” Nick said.

“Too bad. I’ve logged some serious hours pursuing that strategy,” Vince quipped.

“Never too late to change horses,” Nick said.

“Until the race starts,” Vince replied.

“You’d be surprised some of the things I’ve seen happen on a race track,” Nick said. “That will have to wait for another day, though, because I need to finish moving all this crap before the others arrive.”

“Who all is joining in your little festivity, anyway?”

“Mary took her last final yesterday, so she’s down. Hershel, Alex, and Will all said they’d be coming. Alice has said she will ‘stop by’ but wouldn’t commit to any more than that. Oh, and I think Will’s sister might come,” Nick



said, ticking off the attendants on his fingers.

“Her name is Jill. It’s one letter off from Will, why is it you can’t ever seem to remember that?” Vince asked.

“Because my brain is just too damn chocked full of knowledge to take on anything new at this point. See what I mean about needing a day off?”

Vince raised his hands in surrender. “Okay, okay, you win. Put me on the list, I’ll spend my day watching television with you guys instead of expanding my mind.”

“If you’re looking for mind expansion, I’m pretty sure those guys who play Ultimate Frisbee on the lawn and listen to indie music keep some on them,” Nick informed him.

“Huh?”

“Never mind, should have known you wouldn’t get that joke, Boy Scout,” Nick said. “So you going to invite your woman?”

“Nah, she’s visiting her parents this weekend,” Vince said.

“Oh, that’s cool that they live close by,” Nick commented.

“They live in Seattle,” Vince said.

“Right. Forgot to adjust normal expectations, my mistake,” Nick said. “Well, if you’re staying then you can help me with the couch.”

“Sure,” Vince agreed. They went to each end of the couch and hefted it up. As they were inching around the room a thought struck Vince.

“If everyone is coming why aren’t we doing this in the main common room?”

“Because Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport occasionally come through there and I thought they might be a bit of a buzzkill on our day,” Nick said in a strained voice.

“Hey, they aren’t that bad. They’d always been really nice to us,” Vince said.

“Not denying that, but they’re adults. Today we’re blowing off legitimate work to piss the day away having fun. That is most definitely adolescent behavior and I feel it will be more enjoyable without any judgmental gazes being cast our way from the kitchen.”

“I thought you said this was a valid stress management technique to improve test performances.”

“Oh Vince, you can’t believe everything you hear these days. Now let’s get to the video store before someone steals my idea and checks out the first season.”

## 58.

“I must say, it warms my heart as an educator to see such a robust turnout this morning,” Coach George announced as he paced along the line of skittish students. “How about you, Persephone?”

“Heart thoroughly warmed,” Coach Persephone answered.

“Glad to hear it. I must say, I thought more of you would break by now. I was certain some would take this opportunity to drop out of the program rather than face today’s exam. You’ve proven me wrong so far, but then the day is just beginning,” Coach George said.

It was indeed just beginning. The students had been told to be lined up in the gym on exam day at seven in the morning sharp. Most, if not all, had arrived early rather than risk seeing what happened to those in strolled in minutes after the deadline. Many of them were still blinking the sleep out of their eyes, but they were in attendance and paying attention with the vigor that only fear can provide.

“I’m sure many of you are wondering what today’s test is. Well, as most of you know, this is the last chance any of you will have to show us which training course you’ll be placed in next semester. As such, the only way we felt we could accurately measure your abilities was to pit you against one another,” Coach George continued.

Some of the higher ranked students perked up. If it was just going to be fighting they were confident they would sail through this day easily.

“Now, before anyone gets too excited, this won’t be like your first day. I don’t just want to see who can kick the shit out of each other. I want to see who can think on their feet, adapt to a changing environment, and yes, a little bit of shit kicking will be in there too. You see, my little freshmen, today you enter the labyrinth.”

The student glanced at one another with confused stares.

“As you all know, we’re located underneath the actual Lander campus. What most of you don’t know, though, is that this is the top level of our subterranean stronghold. Farther down are other levels, whole environments designed to simulate real-life situations for training purposes. At the very bottom is a level we call the labyrinth. Constantly moving, always shifting, it’s a maze that would make you go crazy if you were abandoned there. Today, it will also be your battleground,” Coach George said.

Coach Persephone stepped forward holding two boxes. She began at one end of the line, fitting small bracelets on each student and handing out what looked like tasers that had been dipped in paint.

“My colleague is equipping you with the tools for your exam. Each of you will be given a bracelet and a weapon that is color coded. The bracelets will turn yellow on those of you who can be injured by mundane means, while they will be red for those who are only susceptible to more extreme forms of damage. By the same token, if you have a power that allows you to deal out tremendous damage, you get a red weapon, and if you lack that skill, you get a yellow one. How the game works from here is simple. The weapons generate a specifically calibrated electrical pulse that reacts with the bracelets, so if someone strikes you, it will deactivate your bracelet. Once you’re deactivated, you’re out,” Coach George explained.

Coach Persephone was making her way down the line quickly; nearly half the students had already been outfitted. Those that had received their new equipment quickly took the time advantage to familiarize themselves with it. It didn’t take long: there was no interface for the bracelets and only a single button on the tasers. Some of the smarter ones began to idly wonder just how the bracelet knew what color to turn once it was attached to them.

“Now, that should be simple enough to understand, but in the interests of realism, we added the color coding system. Those with red bracelets can only be taken down with shocks from red weapons, while those with yellow bracelets are susceptible to both kinds. Additionally, since some of you folks change form in the course of a fight, the bracelets use a very complex sensor system to determine which category you fall into. That means if you’re only extra durable when you’re composed of steel then your bracelet will only be red when you fit that requirement.”

There was a sound like a sword being pulled across an anvil and suddenly Stella was silver all over. The bracelet on her wrist flashed three times, then turned red.

“So, we know how the game is played. Next comes the question of winning. That is the easy part. You win by surviving and destroying. The three who stay in the game the longest and the three who deactivate the most other students all get the best scores. Everyone else gets evaluated on an individual performance basis. That’s pretty much it. Use your powers as needed, but remember that unless your weapon connects with the other person, no amount of damage counts as a win for you.”

“This sounds fun,” Nick whispered to Vince.

“Really?”

“Are you out of your mind? We’re about to be trapped in a maze with over thirty other people who are all much stronger than I am. Most of whom are stronger than you as well. We’re going to get the hell beaten out of us,” Nick whispered furiously.

“At least we can all work together,” Vince pointed out.

“Now, we’ll be using a random drop chamber so that you’ll all be placed at different locations throughout the labyrinth. You’ll be totally on your own and surrounded by potential enemies. Once you’ve been knocked out of the game, a guide function on your bracelets will activate and take you to the nearest exit. I suggest you don’t dawdle, because while you might be out the others will still be looking for blood,” Coach George continued.

“We are so going to die,” Vince amended.

“Yup,” Nick agreed.

“That pretty much sums it up,” Coach George said. “I could take questions, but I’d rather see you find your answers in the field. When we call your name, follow Persephone to the drop chamber. Once you arrive, consider the game started. Remember we’ll be watching all the moves you make, so be smart in your strategies. Oh, and one more thing.”

Coach George faced them, and a broad grin broke across his face. Many of the students involuntarily shuddered. More would have if they’d been perceptive.

“Have fun down there!”

## 59.

“Pitch black. Of course it’s pitch black. Why would I hope for anything different?” Alice grumbled as she was dropped into a room within the labyrinth. She groped around the walls slowly, finding that the room was blocked off from every direction except for a single exit in the form of an open archway. She floated up a few feet and checked the ceiling too. Whatever opening had allowed her entrance had sealed up immediately afterwards. On the plus side, though, the ceiling were high. Alice was estimating around ten feet. The doorway didn’t extend all the way to the ceiling, but if she only had to lower herself to pass through doors that still might work out to be a pretty good deal.

“Yellow weapon and yellow bracelet. Yeah, I’ll be out of here in time to get breakfast,” she said, talking to herself in an effort to keep focused. It was disorienting to be in this much darkness. Not even her bracelet gave off any light, which, given that it had a glow system incorporated, was odd. Still, she should probably be thankful that it wasn’t exuding light. It would have stood out like a beacon in this environment. At least now she could hug the ceiling and have a fighting chance of lasting.

\* \* \*

Mary wasn’t all that put out by the darkness. As soon as she landed she opened her mind, stretching the perception until she could hear the thoughts of nearly every other student in the labyrinth with her. After a few moments of careful hunting, she located the thoughts of the person she was looking for and began making her way to him. It was slow going without any source of light, but Mary could feel his direction. Plus, she was well aware of any others that were approaching so she steered clear of them.

It wasn’t that Mary didn’t plan on fighting; it merely wasn’t beneficial for her, yet. She moved quickly and carefully through the corridors, feeling the occasional student grow close to her and listening to the grinding shifts as new doors opened while others closed. She was still listening to everyone’s thoughts and was accumulating some very useful facts about how the labyrinth functioned; however, at no point did she deviate from her plan or alter the goal of her path.

At long last she reached a closed door. She felt around the side and located the switch. As the door slid open she was temporarily blinded by the deluge of light assaulting her eyes. After a few seconds to adjust and a myriad of blinks she was finally able to see again.

“Hey there, stranger,” she said, greeting the room’s other inhabitant. “Need a hand?”

\* \* \*

Roy was on a one-man rampage. So far he’d taken down a stretchy guy and some weird chick with dolls. Now he was hot on the trail of someone else, though whom was anyone’s guess in the damn darkness. He’d been lucky and found a lighted room to fight the first two in, but after twenty minutes of waiting he’d given it up and started roaming the corridors, looking for more prey.

Roy could hear the footsteps ahead of him and didn’t bother to disguise his own. If whoever was in front of him was lucky enough to have a red taser they still wouldn’t be able to pinpoint his location fast enough to stop him. Instead he barreled forward, forgoing all manner of stealth in favor of a full on charge. He heard the steps in front of him quicken as well and the chase was on.

Roy’s senses were above a normal human’s range but they were far from the most powerful thing about him. Still, it was enough to keep track of the person running away from him. They were crafty, moving around corners and doubling back down corridors, but they weren’t good enough to beat Roy. As far as Roy was concerned, no one held that distinct honor. With each turn he was drawing closer and closer, and as he rounded one last corner, he was positive he was almost right on top of prey.

As Roy swung around the corner a blast hit him square in the chest, slamming him back against the wall. His head swam and he saw stars as he tried to pull himself back up. His efforts were interrupted by a small jolt to his neck. It wasn’t enough to incapacitate or even annoy him. It was only enough to cause his bracelet to glow white in the darkness and emit a small, sad beep.

“And another one bites the dust,” said a cheery female voice at his side.

“You ambushed me,” Roy said accusingly.

“Don’t be silly. I trapped you. That’s way more effort than a simple ambush. Thanks for playing though.”

A small green arrow appeared on the bracelet, pointing to the left. As Roy stood up and angled himself in that direction the arrow moved as well, turning until it was facing forward.

“What’s your name?” Roy asked.

“Amber,” said the voice in the darkness.

“Amber,” Roy said, tasting the name and memorizing its flavor. “That was a hell of a shot. You and I will have to spar one day when this is all over.”

“Sounds fun. You bring the muscles, I’ll bring the concussions,” Amber said.

\* \* \*

Vince turned another corner and entered into a new room. It was as dark as the others, but this one had the added adornment of muffled breathing in the corner. Vince’s hand tightened around his weapon. He had a red taser, so theoretically he could take down anyone here, but if it was someone with real combat skill he’d be at a disadvantage if he gave his location away. Never in his life did Vince suspect he would be so thankful to all the times he and his father had snuck aboard a train at night or crept through town silently. Those experiences had taught him to shroud the sounds of his movements, and right now that was likely the only thing keeping the other person in the room from leaping.

Vince readied himself to take the offensive, he’d already prepared an attack plan as soon as he’d arrived in this endless black environment. Before he could strike, though, the other person took him completely by surprise.

“Vince?” The voice was very familiar, it only took Vince a moment to realize who he’d been on the brink of battling.

“Alex? Is that you?” Vince asked.

“Yeah, it’s me,” Alex confirmed.

“How did you know who I was?”

“Man, you guys always forget my power lets me sense others’ minds. We’ve hung out enough to where yours is familiar,” Alex explained.

“That’s... cool,” Vince said, only barely stopping himself from using the word “creepy” instead.

“Comes in handy,” Alex replied. “So... how are things?”

It dawned on Vince that neither of them were sure how to proceed from here. Yes, they had run into a friend, but this was still their test. They both needed to take down others while simultaneously surviving. Still, Vince didn’t know if he had it in him to just coldly attack someone he considered a friend.



“Hey, Alex,” Vince said. “In all of Coach George’s ranting, did he ever say we couldn’t work together? I mean, if you and I wanted to team up with someone we trusted on the hopes of increasing our score, I don’t think that violates any of the test rules.”

“That’s true. He said survive and destroy. He never got specific about how we do it,” Alex agreed.

“I like that solution a lot better than us duking it out in the dark,” Vince said.

“You and me both. So we work together until we’re the only two left?”

“I think that would be a beautiful problem to encounter,” Vince said cheerfully. “Let’s get moving.”

\* \* \*

Nick was the only one of the five to be dropped into a room that was lit when he arrived. Rather than leaving his cocoon of light, though, he sat down in the center of the room and began concentrating. Nick had known his plan the minute Coach George had explained the game to them. Nick was going to do nothing.

Well, nothing physically, anyway. Nick’s strategy was a focused, steady stream of luck geared that he hoped would keep him hidden. People were wandering around a maze with no sense of direction or idea where they were going. They were depending almost entirely on luck to guide them, and since Nick happened to hold some sway in that department, it should be guiding them anywhere else but to him.

Admittedly, it wasn’t the most ambitious of plans, but given the circumstances it would ideally ensure that he lasted into the final three survivors. The top head hunting positions were all still open, though Nick was under no disillusions that he’d ever had a shot at claiming one of those. Instead he put his efforts and power into making sure he stayed all alone in his little room for as long as possible.

It seemed to be working for a while, but then at once the door in front of Nick slid open. It was difficult to see outside; apparently it was pitch black in the next room over. Nick made no movement to get up from his seat. If someone had found him then they had found him, and if it was just the labyrinth being weird then he wasn’t going to interrupt his concentration. A few seconds after the door opened, though, a familiar voice came wafting in from the darkness.

“Hey there, stranger. Need a hand?”

## 60.

“Not even a little bit,” Nick replied. “Thanks for the offer, though. Try not to give away my position on your way out of here.”

“Really? Just kicking me out? Where’s that legendary Nick wit and chatty nature?” Mary asked.

“Seen any good movies lately? How’s the folks? Cold enough for you these days? Get the hell out of here.”

“Now that wasn’t so hard,” Mary said, walking fully into the room. The door swooshed shut automatically as she left its proximity.

“Yet you’re still coming in. For a telepath you sure can’t take a hint,” Nick sighed, rising to his feet. “Or maybe you’re thinking of zapping me and upping your stats.”

“Or, and this is just a crazy idea, I want us to help each other so we can do better in this trial,” Mary said.

“Who needs help here? I had a perfectly good plan and you’re the number one rank on the girls’ side. Pretty sure we’ll be just fine on our own,” Nick said.

“You know Nick, the word ‘us’ can mean more than just the two people currently standing in a room together,” Mary pointed out.

“So let me get this straight: you want me to abandon my safe little hidey hole so that I can go with you, charging through a labyrinth, all in the name of helping our dorm mates?” Nick asked.

“Everyone except Roy. He’s already out of the game,” Mary confirmed.

“Oh, well, that changes everything,” Nick said, throwing his hands up dramatically. “They’ll be fine. I mean, they’ll lose, and quickly, but they’ll be fine in the long run.”

“Are you sure about that? You know this test is going to determine who moves on to next semester. What if they do so badly they get cut from the program?” Mary asked.

“Then we buy them a conciliatory fruit basket and move on with our lives,” Nick said.

“You can act as blasé as you want about this, Nick, but don’t forget I peek inside your head more than occasionally. You and I both know that you’ve put in a ton of time working this group, creating just the right persona and positioning yourself precisely where you want to be in the group dynamic.”

“And your point here is?” Nick asked.

“You aren’t the kind of guy who will let all that hard work go down the drain if it’s avoidable. The best way to make sure your efforts bear fruit is to keep the group the way it is, and that means everyone advancing to next semester,” Mary explained.

“See, this... this is why I hate telepaths,” Nick all but swore. “Fine. Lead on, oh champion of the misfit Supers.”

“I think I’ll do just that,” Mary said with a smile, opening the door once more and stepping out into the unknown.

\* \* \*

Alice’s strategy was panning out well so far. She’d heard more than a couple of fellow students padding beneath her, but thus far none of them had discerned the floating blonde over their heads. Once or twice she’d briefly entertained the idea of dropping on top of them in surprise and trying to shock them out of the game. Common sense and awareness that her weapon was only effective on a select few had ultimately prevailed and helped her adhere to her hiding strategy.

As time ticked away, Alice noticed fewer and fewer students passing beneath her. Of course some were being eliminated, but it seemed to be happening with alarming frequency. It began to occur to her that she might just have a shot at being one of the last people standing, as long as she kept herself hidden, of course. It was this need that kept her moving, carefully crossing doorways only when she was positive there was no one else waiting on the other side. She could have stayed still in one room, and in fact tried to at one point, but standing alone in utter darkness and silence is far more terrifying than moving through it with a purpose.

Alice tried to keep her method of movement simple. She alternated left and right turns, not really caring about tracking her own movements, only wanting to avoid back-tracking if possible. She also noticed occasionally that when she was in a room, the door she entered through would close and two others would open. If she’d been hoping to get a sense of where she was, this might have been discouraging. As it was, being lost suited her just fine.

As she navigated through the catacombs of darkness she ultimately came upon a room with something unique in it: a door that required being physical opened. If there had been another way out of the room, she likely would have taken it, but the curiosity was her only option for pressing forward, so Alice groped around until her hand struck a small switch.

The first thing that struck Alice was the overwhelming brightness of the light that assaulted her eyes as the door slid open. The second was the ridiculous amount of wind that smashed against her. For a few brief and very confusing seconds Alice truly believed she had somehow opened up a door leading into a hurricane. Then her eyes adjusted and things made both more and less sense.

Dashing around the room in combat was Sasha, recognizable only when she slowed down enough to change direction or when she clashed with her enemy. The enemy Sasha was fighting was... also Sasha. The duo were duking it out, fighting at insane speeds that were generating the winds Alice had felt.

Alice blinked her eyes to make sure she was seeing things correctly, then very seriously considered flipping that switch again to see if it would make the door close. Unfortunately, before her thoughts could solidify into actions, the pair of Sashas noticed her and shouted in unison.

“Alice! Give me a hand with this imposter!”

\* \* \*

At first Vince was convinced he was hallucinating, but then Alex’s question confirmed what he was seeing.

“Is someone using an orange flashlight?”

Both of them had noticed an orange beam glowing lightly from a few rooms down. It was sweeping erratically, as if wielded by someone trying desperately to make sense of their surroundings.

“Looks that way,” Vince whispered.

“So, do we run away?” Alex asked.

Vince shook his head, then realized Alex could no more see him than vice versa. “No,” Vince said. “There are other people who are too good at moving with stealth for us to have a chance at being the last two standing. Our best chance is to start taking down others when we can find them.”

“Best defense is a good offense,” Alex echoed.

“More or less, though to be honest, I’d feel better if I had a red bracelet to go with my red weapon. Equal out the offense and defense,” Vince whispered back.

“Hey, at least you have one red item. I’m yellow on both accounts,” Alex complained.

“That doesn’t seem right. I mean, I saw them give Mary a red weapon,” Vince said.

“Hey Vince, I think we’re kind of stalling here,” Alex pointed out.

“Oh... yeah, you’re right. We should get moving,” Vince said.

“You should also realize that in total silence the sound of a whisper carries far,” said a familiar voice from one room over. While Vince and Alex had been talking the orange light had gone out and its owner had made his way much closer to the duo. He now stepped through the doorway and reignited his light source, which turned out to be his left hand.

“Thomas!” Vince said happily. “I thought that shade of orange looked familiar. I didn’t know you could use your energy like a light.”

“I can do a lot of things with it,” Thomas replied.

“Man, Nick must have put a whammy of good luck on me before we came down because I keep running into friends,” Vince said, relief evident in his voice. He hadn’t been looking forward to trying to take down another student, no matter how necessary it was.

“I don’t know that I would go that far,” Thomas said, and without another word his right hand burst into orange light as well. Instead of a dim glow, this light arced out and spilt into two beams, one each slamming into Vince and Alex and wrapping around their torso. Their arms were pinned to their sides immediately, and as soon as they were encased they felt themselves lift several feet in the air.

“It’s nothing personal,” Thomas said as he used his left hand to pluck out his own red weapon. The flashlight-like glow vanished, but the pulsating energy emitting from his right hand kept the room amply lit. “It’s as you said, some of us are lacking in the skills to succeed at the stealth portion of this exam. That only leaves bringing down other students.”

“A little warning might have been appreciated,” Vince said, struggling to push against the orange energy enveloping him.

“Appreciated and ill-advised,” Thomas replied. “You are both strong

opponents. Without surprise I doubt I could have taken you both. Such tactics would never be acceptable in a man-to-man fight; however, the environment here seems to suggest it is well within the rules, if not expected.”

“Surprising us was the right idea,” Alex said, an odd smile dancing on his face in the orange light. “Explaining why you did it and giving us time was wrong.”

“My apologies if I gave you hope, but I did so because my abilities have already been tested against telepaths. Your kind deal in moving only solid matter with your minds, and energy is far less dense than that,” Thomas said.

“I’m only going to say this one more time,” Alex said, taking in a deep breath. A vein in his forehead bulged and sweat materialized on his forehead.

“I am not a fucking telepath!”

## 61.

Vince had to admit, he didn't think Alex was going to be able to do anything to Thomas's energy... right up until Alex yelled and the circle binding him was forced apart. Without pause, Alex dropped to the ground, made a quick motion with his hand and flung Thomas across the room. Now, in the time it took Alex to land and attack, Thomas could have easily struck again or made some move to defend himself. The trouble was that while Vince was slightly surprised by Alex's ability to push away energy, Thomas was absolutely flabbergasted. He stood in dumb shock as Alex's force gripped him and sent him crashing into the wall. When he struck, his concentration faltered, and the energy binding Vince dissipated.

"That was pretty cool," Vince said as he landed carefully on the hard stone below.

"Thanks," Alex said. "Sorry about the yelling. It just gets frustrating sometimes."

Vince made a very precise mental note to never question the origins of Alex's power to his face. "I hope you didn't hurt him too badly."

"I am fine," Thomas answered, rising to his feet. "I'd like to know what trick you used, though. You should not be able to stop energy. How did you do it?"

Alex shrugged. "Nothing is beyond the Force."

"Very well, then," Thomas replied. "It seems I will have to fight you both head-to-head. I had hoped to avoid that, but if it must be, then it must be." He lit up again, this time both hands glowing bright orange. Without warning, five beams from each hand lanced out directly at Vince and Alex. They were ready this time, though; Vince rolled to the side and Alex held up a hand, knocking the beams away. As Vince pulled himself back up, he pinned his attention on Thomas, readying himself for the next volley. He noticed that Thomas's hands still showed ten beams extended. Vince put it all together just in time, leaping forward and narrowly missing the five that slammed down in the spot where he had been.

"What the hell?" Vince cried out, ducking to the side as the five orange strands snaked out, each one trying to snare him.

"I told you: my energy moves like an appendage, taking whatever shape I require," Thomas explained from his spot near the wall. "All of them



move independently, and if one of them touches you then you are as good as restrained.”

Vince snuck a glance at Alex, only to see his friend working double time to try and deflect the beams from all angles. While Vince’s five were staying fairly closely-knit, the ones battling Alex were spread out, forcing him to block them at random intervals from every direction. At the rate things were going, Vince and Alex would lose, and soon. All it took was one beam getting through to snare them once more, and even if Alex could get himself free, one had to wonder how many times that trick would work. As for Vince, if he was caught that was probably the end of things.

In a moment of desperation a plan formed in Vince’s head. It was stupid and more than likely wouldn’t work at all. Still, it was a way to lose proactively, and Vince preferred that to just jumping around waiting to be picked off.

“Alex!” Vince called. “I need you to buy me thirty seconds. Can you do that?”

“No idea,” Alex replied. “Guess we’ll find out.” With that, Alex stepped forward and brought to bear all that he had. Thomas’s orange beams were slammed backward against the sheer might of Alex’s will. Try as he might to move them forward, Thomas kept striking an invisible wall, one that didn’t seem to be yielding one bit.

As soon as the beams were restrained, Vince stopped running and bent over. His breathing intensified, indicating he was trying to get his breath back before he tried whatever was to come next. He placed his hands on top of pockets and stared at the ground. He was about to do something crazy. He should be scared, he should be wary, he should be worried. Instead he was exhilarated.

\* \* \*

Before either Sasha could say another word, Alice bounded through the door and flew up to the ceiling. It was higher in this room, at least fifteen feet down to the floor, and Alice hugged it as closely as she could, desperate for every inch she could put between herself and the two women beneath her.

“Someone want to explain what the hell?” Alice called down.

“He’s a mimic!” Sasha yelled.

“No, he is,” the other Sasha countered. “He snuck up on me and grabbed my hand.”

“Okay, so we’re all agreeing that one of you is a mimic at least, right?” Alice asked.

“Yes!” This was yelled in unison by both Sashas. “He can copy your appearance and powers if he touches you,” one of the Sashas elaborated.

“But it isn’t as strong as the original,” the other one chimed in.

“Well, sounds like a good show for me then,” Alice said, crossing her arms.

“Huh?” Technically this wasn’t done in unison, nor was the wording exactly the same, but there are certain gut-generated noises that have a universal meaning, regardless of the particular syllables used to create them.

“The real Sasha is faster, so she’ll win,” Alice said simply. “Seems like this will sort itself out.”

“It isn’t that simple,” Sasha informed her. “I’m not used to fighting someone who can keep up with me.”

“Yeah,” Sasha agreed. “He’s used to dealing with all kinds of powers, so even if I’m a little faster, he’s still got enough combat experience to give me hell.”

“Then what do you want me to do? In case you didn’t notice, I’m not exactly king of the combat hill myself,” Alice retorted.

“Just come lend a hand,” Sasha said.

“With two of us it’ll be that much harder for him,” Sasha pointed out.

Alice paused and gave it some thought, then pulled out her own yellow weapon. “Okay, Sashas, one question before I decide who to help. Your boyfriend is Vince, so you’ve spent a lot of time with us in Melbrook through the semester. So then, who is Mary’s best friend?”

“You,” said one of the Sashas.

“Hershel,” said the other.

“Bingo,” Alice said, dropping down next to the girl who had answered ‘Hershel’ and putting her weapon at the ready. “Let’s get this faker,” she said, smiling at the Sasha next to her and glaring at the one across from them.

“You got it-OW!” The Sasha responding was the one next to her. Coincidentally, it was also the one Alice had slammed her weapon into the neck of as soon as she had looked across at her identical counterpart. The bracelet

on her wrist flashed yellow, then turned clear as a small green arrow appeared in one spot.

“Damn it,” Sasha swore, and as Alice watched in fascination her features seemed to melt together, shifting and squirming until Alice found herself staring at a boy shorter than she with light hair buzzed close to the head. “I’m impressed. I didn’t think you were planning the double cross. See you girls back up top.” With that he made his way to the exit indicated by the arrow and stepped out of the room.

“That was amazing!” Sasha squealed. She walked over to Alice and gave her a hug. “How did you know he was the fake one just by that?”

“I didn’t,” Alice replied.

“You... wait what?” Before the words were fully formed, Sasha felt Alice’s weapon dig into her side, sending its charge into her and eliminating her from the test.

“I said I didn’t know. I just asked a generic question you’d both answer. The one I picked to surprise was random,” Alice explained.

“But... you just eliminated the real me, too,” Sasha said in a hurt voice, still holding onto Alice in their now very-awkward hug.

“Yes, I did. I’d feel a lot worse about it if I hadn’t noticed you adjust your grip on your weapon before coming in for this hug,” Alice replied.

“Touché, my fellow crafty lady,” Sasha said, releasing the hug and checking her bracelet. “You’re more dangerous than you look. What would you have done if you’d taken out the real me at first, though?”

“Been eliminated, but done so with at least one win under my belt,” Alice answered.

“Not a bad plan. Good luck with the rest of the test. The longer you’re in here the tougher the remaining opponents will be,” Sasha informed her.

Alice nodded her understanding, then made a dash to get back into the relative safety offered by darkness. Also, she made a note to not go into any more of these damn lit rooms.

\* \* \*

“Fudge,” Mary said as she and Nick rounded a corner.

“What?” he asked.

“Someone heard us. Someone tough. Hurry and follow me quickly. There’s a lit room nearby, and we have to get there,” Mary said, quickening her speed to a run.

“Why is it so important we get there?”

“Because I have no idea how to fight this guy in the dark,” Mary replied.

“Do you know how to do it in the light?”

“Not really,” she answered.

“Peachy,” Nick sighed, turning up the speed and following his diminutive guide as fast as he could.

## 62.

The door opened, showing only darkness outside of the well-lit room Nick and Mary had entered only moments before. There was a slight whooshing sound, and then another student was standing in front of them, yellow weapon ready at hand. Small wisps of smoke curled in the air for less than second around the area in which he had appeared. The boy himself wasn't too impressive: short in stature and excessively lean. He had a wide grin on his face, though, one that left Nick feeling disconcerted, given that he and Mary had the advantage in numbers.

"Who's this guy?" Nick asked, plucking out his own weapon and standing ready.

"His name is Gilbert and he's a teleporter," Mary informed him, her red weapon already drawn.

"He also has perfectly good hearing and doesn't necessarily like being talked about as though he weren't in the room," Gilbert added. "Also, come on, there's only like forty of us left, you couldn't be bothered to learn everyone's name?"

"I've got a shitty memory, so sue me," Nick quipped.

"Better idea," Gilbert replied, vanishing from his spot and reappearing behind Nick, lunging forward with his weapon. Nick slid to the side as soon he saw Gilbert disappear, though, so Gilbert's sneak attack cleaved nothing but air. Before Nick could try a thrust of his own, Gilbert was standing on the other side of the room.

"I see how this guy could be problematic," Nick admitted, reorienting himself to face his opponent's new position.

"Exactly," Mary agreed.

\* \* \*

"Any time now!" Alex announced, sweat dripping off his forehead in intense concentration.

Vince took one last deep breath and stood up. Everything had worked so far; that in itself was a victory. Now came the hardest part. Vince put his hand into his left pocket and produced his weapon, the red coloring tinted a sickly shade from Thomas's orange light. Vince felt a rush of adrenaline crash over him, elation not far on its heels. Do or die time. Vince couldn't stop the

grin that crept into the corners of his mouth.

“Clear me a path!” Vince yelled, charging forward without waiting for confirmation. If Alex could still do it then he would; if not then this wasn’t going to work anyway. As Vince pumped his legs, a part of his mind realized that this was only his second real fight since coming to Lander, and once again he was betting heavily on a suicidal charge right at his opponent. He really needed to learn another way to problem solve.

As his heart raced and his feet slapped the concrete floor, Vince noticed he was in Thomas’s range. He hadn’t been snagged yet, though, so that meant Alex was still keeping the energy at bay. There were still several more feet to cover, and as Vince drew closer he realized Thomas’s tendrils were bonding together, striking back with more power. Each attempt seemed to get closer to landing on Vince’s fast-moving form. It was going to be a photo finish.

In the end, Vince very nearly pulled it off. His finger was on the button and his arm almost completely extended when he felt his legs go out from under him. A few inches more and he would have driven his weapon into Thomas’s shoulder. That was simply not the case, though, as Vince was once more jerked into the air, his arms pinned to his torso. Without pause, Thomas lanced a shot of energy over at Alex, easily snaring and capturing him once more. From the way Alex was panting wearily, Vince had a sinking suspicion that he wouldn’t be able to break free again this time.

“Well now,” Thomas said, a little short of breath himself. “That was an impressive move. Marshal all your forces into one all-out attack. Risky, but very nearly effective.”

“Thanks,” Vince said, resisting the temptation to kick his legs futilely. “You were wearing us down the other way, so I figured why not give it a shot.”

“If your partner had been a hair stronger or if you had been just a bit faster... despite all our power, it often seems these fights come down to a very narrow margin of victory,” Thomas said as he lowered Vince to only a few inches off the ground. At the same time an orange tendril emerged and nimbly plucked an object from Thomas’s back pocket. It was his own yellow weapon, and the tendril was soon shaped into a hand holding the device, a finger carefully placed on the button to activate it.

“That really is neat how you can do that,” Vince said, watching the show.

“Thank you, I’ve found it useful. Hands, beams, shields, even needles. My energy takes any form I can think of and stays just as powerful regardless,” Thomas said.

“Very adaptive,” Vince complimented.

“Much appreciated. I am sorry yours was so limiting in this environment,” Thomas said graciously. He maneuvered the weapon upward. There was only a foot or so between himself and Vince, but he was still keeping that buffer, just in case. This silver-haired boy had shown himself occasionally unpredictable.

“I don’t know about that,” Vince said. “I mean, it’s limiting in some senses, but with a little creative risk taking it can actually be pretty useful.”

A “How so?” died on Thomas’s tongue, the victim of a sudden case of shock in multiple senses. Before the innocent words had a chance to be born and greet the world, Vince’s eyes crackled with red lighting, which leapt out and struck Thomas in the chest. The voltage shattered his concentration as well as temporarily disabling his motor skills. It also hurt like hell.

As Thomas felt the twitching in his muscles subside and his vision slowly come back into focus, he noticed his bracelet was now glowing clear with a green arrow. The “How so?” was gone, off to wherever unspoken words go when they are truly forgotten. A new combination was being assembled, though, and this phrase burst into the world unhindered by any outside influences.

“What in the hell was that?”

Vince was standing over him, having been freed when Thomas’s concentration was shattered. He looked vaguely different, and Thomas realized it was because they were being lit only by the meager light from his now clear bracelet.

A clattering sound reach Thomas’s ears, and after bathing the area once more in orange light, he could see that Vince had tossed him his weapon.

“Try it out,” Vince said. “I think you’ll understand then.”

Obediently Thomas picked up the red device and pressed its button. There was nothing, no arc of light from one metal point to the other, no soft hum of electricity, no difference of any kind.

“You drained it,” Thomas mumbled, his tongue still shaking off the after effects of voltage overload. “Shouldn’t that have set off your own

bracelet?”

“I thought it might,” Vince admitted. “That’s why I didn’t do it when I first got down here. Once you were hammering away at us, though, it was obvious we were going to lose eventually. So I decided to give it a whirl.”

“You weren’t catching your breath for the charge,” Thomas said, more to himself than to Vince as understanding set in.

“I was drinking the whole battery down to empty. It was a big risk, because they told us the electricity was calibrated to react specifically with the bracelets. I wasn’t sure if my draining it would alter it anyway, so even when I took the shot I didn’t know if it would work,” Vince explained.

“And if it didn’t then you’d be stuck down here with no way to eliminate other students,” Alex concluded, wobbling his way over and joining them.

“Pretty much,” Vince said. “So I just wanted you to know, the only way I was able to beat you was by taking several gambles that very easily could have totally knocked me out commission.”

“I appreciate the attempts to spare my ego,” Thomas said, slowly rising to his feet. “They are unnecessary, though. I lost in fair battle to strong opponents. I feel no shame in this fight.”

“No hard feelings?” Vince asked, extending his hand.

“It is the nature of the exam,” Thomas said, accepting and shaking back. “You might want to get moving, though. This room has been visibly lit up for some time now. Other students are bound to have noticed.”

“Crap,” Vince said, realization slowly dawning on his face. “Good call. Alex, you okay to move?”

“Winded,” Alex admitted. “I should be fine after a few minutes of rest, though.”

“Good luck,” Thomas told them. “Do well today; I would not want the men who were able to defeat me to be taken down easily.”

“Of course,” Vince said, trying to hide the first trembles in his hands as the adrenaline wore off. He and Alex had pushed themselves to their limits to take down one other competent student. Vince wondered how much more they had left in them to deal with the next challenge.



## 63.

The last five minutes had unveiled some unfortunate truths. The first was that Gilbert could teleport faster than Mary was able to read his mind and anticipate the movement. The second was that while she could grab him, he could easily teleport out of her telekinetic grip. The last was that Gilbert clearly had some gymnastics experience.

“Were your parents monkeys or something?” Nick yelled as he ducked away from one of Gilbert’s attacks. Without missing a beat, Gilbert vanished, reappearing at the other end of the room, doing a flip off the wall and landing perfectly.

“My parents put me in tumbling at an early age. Turns out short guys have an advantage in that field,” Gilbert explained.

“Good for you,” Nick grumbled, pulling himself to his feet, but keeping his eyes trained on Gilbert. “I don’t suppose you’ve thought of a plan yet,” he said to Mary out of the side of his mouth.

“Right now all I’m hoping for is that all that jumping around wears him down faster than dodging winds us,” she replied. Her breath was a little short, and Nick had noticed her movements were slowing ever so slightly. Gilbert, on the other hand, was getting faster if anything. He was clearly in better shape than they were, not to mention he was able to conserve energy by using only the most necessary movements. Running out the clock clearly wasn’t going to work.

“Incoming,” Nick announced as Gilbert disappeared. Trusting his instincts, Nick tumbled to the side, popping up with his weapon at the ready. This time Gilbert had gone for Mary, though; fortunately, she had ducked down in time and smacked him away with a mental punch. He flew back, vanishing from sight then reappearing for a few wall rebounds before coming to rest delicately on his nimble feet.

They were going to lose soon, Nick realized. His own body was beginning to show the first symptoms of wear; from this point it was a steady downhill slide. Gilbert had them in endurance and mobility, so the only chance left was strategy. Unlike Vince, though, Nick wasn’t a fan of all or nothing tactics.

*Mary!* Nick thought forcefully. He needed to talk to her, but giving Gilbert any more information than he had was too risky. Hopefully the girl was still listening to minds around her and would pick up his call.

Hope panned out as Mary jerked her head in Nick's direction and angled her head curiously. Good, she was listening.

*Mary, I need your help to beat this guy. Take both of our weapons with your mind and start attacking with them using the patterns I'll be thinking of. Dodge as necessary, but make sure to follow my patterns perfectly.*

Mary gave a small, almost imperceptible nod, and Nick released his weapon. It dropped by maybe three inches before jerking to a stop and zipping away into the air. Nick barely had time to think of the first pattern before Gilbert was on them again. They managed to avoid him, but neither weapon struck during his brief tenure in their vicinity. This time when he reappeared across the room, though, there was no temporary ceasefire. Nick directed Mary to press the attack, making minor alterations on the pattern's trajectories but continuing without pause. Gilbert had to teleport away, and Nick felt a thin smile appear on his face. They were finally making him reactive instead of proactive, and that was exactly where Nick needed him to be.

It wasn't a perfect system. Gilbert began attacking more frequently, avoiding their weapons and coming at them with a single jump. He stayed longer, too, until Mary knocked him back or the weapons flew over. With each disappearance, Nick saw a little bit more. Finally, just when he was growing sincerely worried about his own stamina, Nick found the opportunity he had been waiting for.

Nick concentrated on a new pattern for Mary to attack with and simultaneously began edging away from her. The margin for error on the timing of what he was about to do would be razor thin. As he'd anticipated, Gilbert ducked and flipped away from the weapons buzzing and circling him. He was clearly about to teleport, merely picking his destination. Just before he made the jump, though, his dodging forced him to turn his back on Nick and Mary for half a second. Nick took off from his spot, dashing with all the speed his storky legs could afford him.

Mid-run it occurred to him that moments like this were probably why so much of the time in gym class was spent conditioning their capacity to run. Gilbert had already teleported out of range of the weapons, but Nick didn't see that. He didn't need to. Nick had been watching and analyzing Gilbert's movements with each jump out of danger. The good thing about using the same pattern when evading was that it made such movements second nature, allowing for faster reaction time. The bad thing was that if your opponent was observant enough, they could use those same habits to predict your movements before you made them. Nick was exceptionally observant.

There was a very small lag between Gilbert disappearing and reappearing, but there was one, and that coupled with the half second he was turned away proved to be just enough for Nick's run. Gilbert appeared directly in front of Nick, his eyes widening in surprise at another person being in a spot he'd clearly anticipated as being empty. Before he could react any more than that, Nick reared back and punched him directly in the side of his head. Gilbert dropped like a politician's approval when raising taxes, smacking the ground and twitching slightly.

Without looking Nick held out his left hand and felt a small smack as his weapon landed in it. The press of a button and a flick of the wrist later found Gilbert with a bracelet that had become clear save only for a small green arrow.

"Think he'll be okay?" Mary asked.

"Nope. But that's why we've got healers," Nick replied, taking a deep breath and getting his bearings.

"You throw a hell of a punch," Mary complimented as she ambled over to him.

"That's the problem with the overly combative types like you and him. You guys forget that just because I wield a metaphysical thing like luck it doesn't mean I can't clean a clock on occasion," Nick said.

"I suppose there's some truth to that," Mary admitted. "You know, if I wasn't in your head, I would have never believed you pulled that off without using any luck."

"Then things are exactly as they should be," Nick said. "I suppose you still want to keep looking for our dorm mates."

"You could have said our friends," Mary pointed out.

"Yes, that was also a verbal option. Not the one I elected to use, though."

"Nick, Nick, Nick," Mary said with a shake of her head. "You still have so far to come."

"Emotional growth can wait for later. Right now let's just get this test over with," Nick said.

\* \* \*

"Do you hear something?" Alex whispered as he and Vince crept

through the dark.

"Kind of," Vince whispered back. He wasn't quite sure what was reaching his ears. It wasn't the scrape of shoes against the concrete beneath them, or the hurried hustle of a fellow student moving to a new location. It was softer and slightly harmonic. As he and Alex stepped into a new room, the sound bounced off a nearby wall and magnified significantly. Only then did the two finally realizing what they were hearing.

"Someone is singing," Alex said, his voice not as hushed as it should have been.

"Mmhhh," Vince replied. He should have been more worried about Alex not hiding his voice, or more curious about what would cause someone to be giving away their position by singing. These were thoughts that might have been scrambling around in his mind, but if such thoughts existed, they were lost in a fog growing thick within his brain. Without wondering why, Vince began moving toward the sound of the song. A part of him dimly registered Alex coming as well. It was noted, in a very abstract sort of fashion, and then promptly forgotten.

The two students moved more swiftly through the dark halls, the song bouncing off the walls and guiding them clearly. At last they came to a halt in a dark room like any other, save for the fact that in this one dwelled the singer who had brought them here. Vince raised his hand and a small flame burned in the center, illuminating the room around them.

It was a bare concrete room with only one other person. Sitting cross-legged in the center of the floor was a girl Vince barely recognized from class. She had long, dark hair and olive skin. He remembered at one point thinking she was pretty looking. Now he was transfixed by her beauty, amazed he had ever found the strength to tear his eyes from her. He knelt down in front of her, bringing out more fire so he could see her better. This time he didn't even notice that Alex was following suit. There was no room in his mind for anything else. The test, the program, the world all paled in comparison. There was only her. Her and the song.

She never stopped singing, not as she reached into her pocket and produced an oddly familiar yellow device, not as she pressed it to Alex's temple and he collapsed to the ground, not even as she held against Vince's eager skin.

It was only when Vince came back around that the song had stopped, and by then his bracelet was clear and it was far too late to matter.

## 64.

"Stella?"

"Nope," Nick replied.

"Will?"

"Totally," Nick said.

"Alice?"

"No doubt," Nick told her.

"Really?" Mary said uncertainly. "She's so pretty, and I've heard her thoughts wander in that direction several times before. You sure?"

"Daddy issues with an overprotective emotionally distant father. Not saying she won't be busting wild in days to come, but as of now I'm positive she's a virgin," Nick said.

"I really have trouble believing you can deduce whether someone has had sex just by briefly meeting them," Mary said.

"You can see in my head. Am I lying?"

"I said I have trouble believing, not that I didn't believe," Mary pointed out.

The two were trekking through the darkness of the halls, still in search of their fellow companions. Mary's mental eavesdropping had steered them away from more potential fights, but they'd been forced to take some twists and turns that took them farther from their goal. The tension had culminated in boredom, which had led to conversation and had ultimately found them having the current conversation. Adrenaline and fear are powerful silencers; however, even sneaking through a pitch black labyrinth can grow tedious after enough time.

"So, what about Hershel?" Mary asked.

"Oh, come on, as much as he moons over you there is no way his brain hasn't given that one away," Nick said.

"I try not to listen. It didn't seem polite," Mary explained.

"Not polite? You dig through my head like a hobo scrounging for food outside a restaurant dumpster, but he's a no-fly zone?" Nick said, his voice

rising octaves in mock-outrage.

"He doesn't have anything to hide, nor does he need the advanced levels of therapy you do. Besides, he's romantically interested in me. It seemed like a poor idea to listen to the thoughts of someone I might end up dating," Mary said.

"Hrumph," Nick hrumphed. "Yes, by the way. Still pure as the driven snow."

"That's nice," Mary said, grateful that Nick couldn't see her smile in the darkness.

"Advanced therapy, huh?"

"You've got some issues."

"National Geographic has issues," Nick said. "I have personality."

"You have a complete inability to trust anyone," Mary pointed out. "I mean, you don't even trust Vince, and that kid thinks of you as his best friend."

"Friends stab you in the front," Nick mumbled.

"Real cute. On that note, Vince?"

"Surprisingly, no. And before you ask, not with Sasha. She's not either, but the two of them haven't knocked boots. Not with each other, I mean," Nick said.

"Wow. They've been dating for months now. Wonder what's holding them back," Mary speculated.

"He's a gentlemen and she thinks he's a virgin and doesn't want him to think she's a slut," Nick answered.

"I thought I was the telepath," Mary said.

"Please," Nick scoffed. "Nothing new in that story. Admittedly, usually the guy is only pretending to be a gentleman, but the context is the same."

"Shut up," Mary said quickly. Had Nick been a bit dumber or a touch more sensitive he might have thought she was silencing him after his last comment. Instead he merely shut his yapper. Moments later he heard footsteps echoing toward them. The intruder came close, then turned away a few rooms later. The steps faded away quickly, but he stayed quiet until Mary

signaled the all clear.

"We're okay now," she told him finally. "Also, that is terribly jaded view of the courting process."

"Funny how 'reality' and 'jaded' seem to mean the same thing at the end of the day," Nick shot back.

"Whatever, Mr. Sad Sack. You know what I find to be 'reality'? That you've been here as long as we have, experienced this new environment, and started acting like a real Super just like we four. But you haven't grown or changed one bit. Hershel's popping out of his shell, Roy's calming down and getting focused, Alice is letting herself make connections to people, and Vince is getting used to having structure. Not Nick, though; you've the same guy today as you were when we first met," Mary said.

"I grew up a long time ago," Nick said, a few strands of bitterness snaking into his voice. "Besides, I notice you weren't on that list either, Miss High and Mighty."

"Of course I'm growing. I'm learning to play chess," Mary corrected him.

"Oh, well then, my mistake," Nick said.

"Apology accepted," Mary said. "Alex?"

"Nope," Nick told her. "But then no surprise there. Super in a small town is bound to have some fans."

"I suppose you have a point," Mary admitted. "We're almost there, by the way."

"About time," Nick complained as they loped carefully through the darkness. "Who is it?"

"Why? Hoping for someone in particular?"

"Yes: Roy. We need another heavy hitter. Too bad he's out of the game."

"You're lying," Mary informed him. "Why don't you want to admit that you'd prefer we find Vince? You and he hang out plenty of the time. There's nothing wrong with wanting your friend to help during a stressful situation."

"I don't have friends. Just assets," Nick told her.

"I ought to knock you on your asset," Mary snapped. "Anyway, you'll see who it is in a minute or two anyway."

"Fine," Nick snapped. He needed to get his game face back on. Soon they'd have company and that meant Nick the quip-filled chatterbox, not Nick the conniver. He couldn't hide things from Mary; however, that was no excuse to let himself get sloppy in front of others.

"You're really pathetic sometimes," Mary scolded. Nick blinked, then realizing she was rebuking him for his thoughts rather than any recent words.

"I gotta be me," Nick told her. He hesitated for a minute as a question popped into his head. He was about to stifle it, then he realized Mary had heard it already now so he might as well ask. "Does Vince really think of me as his best friend?"

"And trusts you without hesitation," Mary assured him. "Kind of sad, knowing the man you really are."

"Yeah yeah yeah, be careful you don't fall off that soapbox."

The two stepped through a series of arches rapidly and stopped in a dark room like any of the others they'd been in over the last hour.

"Speaking of being elevated, ahoy up there!" Mary called, her voice echoing off the ceiling.

"Mary?" Alice's tentative voice drifted down.

"And Nick," Nick tossed in.

"Oh great," Alice groaned from her vantage point on the ceiling. "You had to be tagging along."

"You know me, Princess, one for all and all for one. We're passing this test as a team," Nick lied.

"Well, to be technical, we're the last of the team," Mary said. "Vince and Alex went down about fifteen minutes ago."

Nick whistled. "Who took those two out?"

"Let's just say if you hear someone singing, run like hell," Mary told him.

"Um, guys, not that I'm not thankful to have company, but I'm guessing you two have some sort of plan?" Alice asked.



"My plan was to round up as many of us as I could," Mary said. "As of now I'm officially open to suggestions."

"Might I recommend surrender," said a new voice in the room, one that didn't immediately register to its other inhabitants. Nick wasn't the only one with decent deductive skills, though; it only took Mary a moment to confirm her fears and the mystery voice's owner.

"Hi, Chad," she said weakly.

## 65.

"You sure it's him?" Nick half-whispered.

"Seeing as he's the only student in our class whose thoughts I can't hear, yeah, I'm pretty sure," Mary confirmed.

"Ahem. It's dark, I get that. I am still standing right here, though," Chad called out.

"Oh no, we've offended him. Now he'll easily beat us and knock us out of the test. A totally different outcome than what he was already planning," Nick said.

"Actually, I was planning to let you and Alice go," Chad corrected. "Neither of you pose a good fight for me."

"Really?" Alice asked from overhead.

"Yes. Mary stays, though. I imagine she will make an interesting opponent," Chad informed them.

"Cool by me!" Nick declared. "Alice, fly your ass down here and let's book."

"But... what about Mary?" Alice asked hesitantly.

"I appreciate the sentiment, Alice, but you should go. Chad is a strong Super, so fighting him is likely to cause a lot of collateral damage. It will be easier if I don't have to worry about hitting either of you in this darkness," Mary told her.

"You're sure?"

"Of course. I'll catch up with you two later. Now hurry up," Mary instructed her.

"You heard the girl, time for us to exit, stage right," Nick told her.

Without any more coaxing Alice floated down to Nick's side and the two slowly made their way into another room. They stumbled along into another hallway and were lost once more in the endless twists of the labyrinth. Neither Chad nor Mary said anything until their footsteps had totally faded away.

"You lied to your friend," Chad said matter-of-factly.

"Yes, I did," Mary admitted.

"That was very kind of you," he complimented.

"It was kind of you to let them go," she returned.

Mary heard something that sounded suspiciously like a shrug. "I meant what I said. Their powers aren't suited for combat. I won't learn anything from them or be suitably challenged. I gain no satisfaction from defeating weaker opponents."

"You and me both," Mary said. "Though I don't think that's applicable to either of us in this case."

"No, it is certainly not," Chad agreed. With that, he rushed forward.

\* \* \*

"Holy crap!" Nick exclaimed as they heard a tremendous smashing sound some yards behind them.

"Ditto," Alice seconded. "Do you think she's okay?"

"I'm sure she's fine," Nick lied hurriedly. "We should be moving faster."

"You think Chad will change his mind?"

"I think there is a metric fuckton of power being flexed uncomfortably close to my proximity and I'd like to increase that meager bit of distance," Nick clarified, quickening his pace.

"You make a compelling case," Alice agreed, matching his speed. "This doesn't seem a little wrong to you, though? I mean, we're here learning to be Heroes. Doesn't running away go counter to that?"

"Only if your definition of a Hero is someone who gets needlessly pummeled," Nick replied. "You and I have precise, useful talents. Kicking ass isn't in either of our repertoires though."

"Maybe if we teamed up-" Alice began.

"We could have hamstrung the only one of the three of us with an outside shot of winning," Nick finished. "Moments like this are exactly why I'd guess they're splitting us into combat and alternative training. To illustrate when a strategic removal of forces is more beneficial than a grand last stand."

"You sure jazzed up the concept of running away there," Alice said.

"Why thank you, Princess, I consider it my gift. Since when are you so concerned about Mary's well-being anyway?"

"She came looking for me. Both of you did. Something sits wrong with me hightailing it away from her now that things are rough," Alice justified.

"And I here I just thought you were growing chummy with our diminutive mind-reader," Nick said.

Alice tried to brush off his comment; however, she discovered that it didn't brush quite so easily. She wasn't just worried about getting away and she didn't feel guilty purely because she was leaving someone behind. These feelings were more persistent because it was Mary she was running from and Mary who was in danger. At some point in their living situation tolerance had transitioned into fondness. Alice stopped running.

"I'm going back," she declared, turning around.

"No, you're not," Nick told her, pulling himself up short as well. He strode back over to her, groping a bit before finding her precise location in the darkness. "I get it. She's our friend, we care, we want her to be okay and it seems like making a grand stand will facilitate that outcome."

"We'll think of something," Alice said stubbornly.

"We'll distract her, we'll get in the way, and it's possible we'll get hurt or killed. Accidents happen, even with the safety measures the HCP takes. And Mary will blame herself for not being able to protect us. You want to toss in the fact that we're learning to be Heroes? Then remember this: a Hero's first priority is the greater good. You feel inadequate and guilty, so you want to ameliorate those feelings by trying to help. That's selfish, though; it puts your need to feel good about yourself over Mary's need to stay safe and win," Nick lectured her.

"I still feel like shit," Alice admitted, something she didn't think she could have said if she'd been able to see Nick's face.

"Sometimes doing the right thing leaves you feeling like an asshole," Nick told her. "Now move."

\* \* \*

"You're amazing," Chad complimented her. "You can't see me or sense my thoughts, yet you've still managed to last this long. I'm sincerely impressed."

Mary wheezed in a breath and blinked sweat from her eyes. She appreciated the sentiment, but she didn't feel particularly amazing. Fighting Chad was hell. He was fast, strong, had ridiculous endurance, and worst of all he didn't seem remotely fazed by not being able to see. She'd been generating what was essentially a bubble of telekinetic power to stop him, but he'd already broken through twice. She'd released a massive burst and driven him back, but he'd landed glancing blows each time. Not to mention the fact that those massive blasts took a lot of her. She could feel her mental reserves slipping and her bubble weakening.

""Why... can't I read... your thoughts?" Mary rasped out between ragged breaths. She needed him to talk, to buy even a few extra seconds if she could.

"Brains work on certain frequencies through electrical impulses. I've done some extensive remodeling of how mine functions to maximize potential. You could think of it as you pick up FM, but I'm broadcasting on AM," Chad explained.

"Impossible," Mary said.

"No such word. Think of any wonder or miracle in this world and sooner or later you'll find someone with that power. It's just a matter of perseverance. Speaking of, while I admire your attempt to stall in hopes of a better outcome, don't you think it's time we let this dance come to its inevitable conclusion?" Chad asked.

"I suppose," Mary agreed. With one last push of effort she slammed an area nowhere near the last spot Chad's voice had come from, striking in a wide area rather than focusing on a more central point. Mary had tried several attacks already, but no matter how fast she'd been, Chad was always gone by the time her blast hit the area he'd last been. She let her bubble drop and put that energy into the strike as well. This was a last shot gambit, one depending almost entirely on luck. Chad wouldn't be where she'd heard his voice, so the only choice left was to pick a totally different spot and pray for the best. There was a smashing sound as her force struck empty wall, and she knew it was over.

"Well done," Chad's voice said from behind her. "A foot over and you would have hit me. I'd love to fight you again when we're on a more equal ground."

"Sure," Mary agreed. "After break, though. I need a long rest after this."

"Of course," Chad agreed, delicately placing his weapon against her shoulder and giving it a quick pulse.

\* \* \*

"Finally, sweet light," Nick said as the door slid open and he stumbled into the lit room. Alice followed suit, though more cautiously. Her last light room encounter was a bit too fresh in her mind to leave her at ease.

"The loud noises have stopped," Alice pointed out as Nick walked to the center of the room and dropped to a sitting position.

"I noticed. We'll wait here for five minutes to see if Mary joins us," Nick told her.

"And if she doesn't?"

"More wandering in the dark. Staying mobile and hidden are our best bets at that point," Nick said.

"You say that like there was a point when that wasn't our only option," Alice pointed out.

"Well, with Mary we could have pulled off a little magic. Just you and me, though, we're less useful. Have to face facts; this challenge was designed to favor combat types," Nick sighed.

Nick waited for a reply, but when one didn't come he turned around to face Alice. He'd expected to see her lost in thought or worry, annoyed at being stuck with him again. Instead what greeted his eyes was her collapsed form and a barely noticeable pale glow from her wrist.

"Shit," Nick swore, scrambling to get on his feet. He reacted quickly, but not quickly enough. A sharp pain emanated from his gut and dropped him right back to the floor. As his vision cleared he saw a female figure ripple into view. She was a fellow student, of course, one with short, mousy hair and a cocky grin.

"I don't know," she said, jumping into the conversation. "I find that a power is as useful as the person wielding it."

"Well, crap," Alice said weakly from her spot on the floor. Nick felt that summed it up nicely.

## 66.

Hershel tossed another shirt into his suitcase while Nick and Vince lounged about, watching TV. Hershel had decided to do his packing in the boys' lounge to spend a little more time with his dorm mates before the trek home. It was the day after the exam and the mood was surprisingly upbeat.

"I still can't believe everyone passed," Vince declared yet again. It was a bit of a surprise that all of the students had been told they would be returning next semester, and from Vince's reaction, he must have been placing himself as a particularly high candidate for elimination.

"I still can't believe we all got beaten by girls," Nick chimed in, folding his arms bitterly.

"What are you, five? Who cares if we lost to girls, I'm just happy we get to keep going," Vince said, switching the channel to some competitive cooking show.

"It's a point of manly pride," Nick said defensively. "Though I have to admit, yours had a pretty awesome power."

"Enchanting people through song," Vince said with a shake of his head. "I talked to her afterward; apparently she can make people feel all sorts of stuff with her singing. Adoration was just the easiest."

"I'm glad it was you and not Roy. Heaven knows how he would have reacted if he actually liked a girl," Hershel laughed.

"What about Julia? I thought those two hooked up fairly consistently?" Vince asked.

"They do, but that's only because of how... unique her power makes her," Hershel said, opting to skip over the more lurid details.

"Very diplomatic way of saying she's her own gang bang," Nick said.

"Right... anyway, Selena, the girl who can sing, told me she snared a bunch of others before and after me. I wouldn't be surprised if she's toward the top in knocking out other players," Vince said.

"So nice of them to tell us we're all coming back but then hide our scores and which training we'll be going into," Nick said.

"Oh, come on, it's not as if anyone would stay for the results anyway," Hershel pointed out. "Alex, Will, and Jill already left town yesterday."

"Sasha, too," Vince pointed out. "Though she does that with more ease than most, so I'm not sure if that counts."

"I don't blame them," Hershel said with a sigh. "I miss my mom and my town. I can't wait to get home and sleep in my own bed."

"It will be nice to get some real food," Nick agreed. "Hey Vince, where are you going for the holidays anyway?"

Vince was spared from having to answer by the door to the boys' lounge opening to reveal Mr. Numbers.

"Before anyone leaves, Mr. Transport and I would like to see you all in the common room," Mr. Numbers said briskly, turning around and walking right back out.

"That wasn't creepy at all," Nick said once Mr. Numbers was out of earshot.

"I'm sure they just want to wish us safe travels over the holidays," Hershel said optimistically.

"Sure. That or the order came down to terminate their little project and bury us in shallow graves," Nick replied.

"Let's be realistic. It'd be much easier for Mr. Transport to just ditch us in a volcano or something," Vince said.

"Point conceded," Nick said as they walked out into the lounge. Alice and Mary were already there, and of course the two men wearing suits were standing in the center, just like they had that first day they'd popped in and scared the crap out of everyone.

"So, what's this about?" Hershel whispered to Mary as the boys ambled over and stood near the girls.

"Let's call it a surprise," Mary whispered back, her tone saying quite clearly that was the end of the subject.

"Thank you all for coming," Mr. Transport announced with a big smile. "Mr. Numbers and I wanted to take a moment to congratulate you on making it an entire semester. As you know all too well by now, this program is grueling physically as well as mentally, so we are very proud that one hundred percent of Melbrook students have lasted into the second semester."

"And surprised," Mr. Numbers tossed in.

"Well, yes, statistically this does count as an unexpected outcome,"



Mr. Transport tried to recover. "We know, though, that you've all made it this far through determination and hard work. You five are doing an excellent job in showing that years of practice with one's abilities don't matter nearly as much as heart."

"We are very happy to have done so," Alice said, all but beaming. The girl devoured praise and accolades.

"That's good," Mr. Transport said. "Because there is one more small task we need to take care of before you're released for Winter Break."

It wasn't the change in scenery that registered first with the five young students: it was the sudden slice of freezing wind ripping across their bodies. The shivers started immediately, as well as a reflexive search for shelter from the scouring wind and the white snow that was dumping down upon them. Everywhere they looked there was only more snow. Everywhere except up, where a huge peak loomed overhead, lost at the top amidst the clouds.

"I hope you've all still got a little bit of gusto left," Mr. Transport yelled over the wind's howl. "I brought you here for what you can think of a final exam for Mr. Numbers and me."

He really didn't have to elaborate. Given the surroundings, there was only one logical conclusion. Giving words to it only served the purpose of hammering that unavoidable truth fiercely into their minds, which would be almost cruel given the circumstances. Mr. Transport didn't have any need to elaborate... but he did anyway.

"You five are going to climb a mountain."

## 67.

"Bullshit," Nick replied, only pure willpower keeping his teeth from chattering.

"Not all, I assure you," Mr. Numbers confirmed. "Your parents have all been made aware that you'll be detained for a few more days. No one is expecting you."

"But... why?" Alice asked, perplexity and cold slowing her words.

"Because you were all admitted as part of a very special program, one that is being measured in different ways than just your grades. Think of this as an extracurricular activity mandated by your scholarship," Mr. Numbers explained.

"This is crazy; we'll freeze to death," Vince pointed out. While Vince was admittedly cold, being trapped in a one-man tundra a few months back made it seem more bearable by comparison.

"Now, don't be silly," Mr. Transport said. "We've left you packs filled with supplies and winter wear. You'll find everything you need to reach the top safely."

"So, that's it? We just climb up?" Nick asked, probing for potential pitfalls.

"Well, there are two caveats. You have to reach the summit together, and you need to do it in six days," Mr. Transport admitted.

"Why six days?" Hershel asked.

"Because that's how much food we gave you," Mr. Numbers said. "There's a phone at the top with a pre-programed number. Call us once you make it and we'll come pick you up."

"Wait, you're leaving us?" Alice all but squawked with incredulity.

"Yes," Mr. Numbers said.

"You're Supers now. Supers find a way," Mr. Transport said, and then both men were gone.

"Motherfuckers." Everyone turned in surprise, because that vulgarity was spat out from the mouth of Mary.

\* \* \*

Ten miserable minutes of trudging forward had revealed a set of five oversized backpacks waiting in the snow. Each was a different color and labeled with a name. Nick's was golden, Alice's pink, Hershel's a dark green, Mary's red, and Vince's blue. It should be noted that none of them gave a shit about that, though; instead they tore into the bags savagely and began piling on clothing. Only after everyone was coated, booted, and gloved did they begin to contemplate a strategy.

"Figures the one time I'd have an advantage they'd screw me over," Alice complained. "I mean, come on, it's a damn climbing challenge! It was basically made for people with flight. But no, we all have to make it up there together or it doesn't count."

"Forgive my impudence here, but how the hell will they know? They left, remember?" Nick reminded her.

"They'll know," Mary assured them. "They went to all the trouble of setting this up, they'll make sure we follow the rules."

"Speaking of, how did you not see this coming, telepathic girl?" Nick asked.

"I did. I just hoped they would change their minds," Mary explained.

"Nice strategy, that one," Nick scoffed.

"It could be worse," Hershel said optimistically. "At least I have my emergency flask on me. This way Roy can help if we need him."

"Why do you keep an emergency flask of whiskey?" Vince asked him.

"Pretty much for situations exactly like this one," Hershel replied.

Vince placed his fingers on the bridge of his nose and sighed. "It saddens me how much sense that makes in this context. Okay: we know what we have to do, so how are we going to do it?"

"They gave us climbing gear, food, Sterno, flashlights, and water," Alice said as she rifled through her bag to take inventory.

"Aside from which we have a flier who isn't allowed to fly, an energy absorber in an environment with nothing he can absorb, enough whiskey for a few appearances of the one person who could do this easily, me, and Mary the marvelous brain girl," Nick said. "If we're going to build a strategy around someone's powers it looks like Mary is our number one candidate."

"He has a point," Vince agreed. "Could you just lift all of us up to the

peak?"

"No," Mary said sadly. "Grabbing hold of a person is a delicate procedure; it isn't like throwing objects. I have to worry about pressure and rupturing organs, that sort of thing. I can do it if I have to with one person, maybe two for short bursts, but I'm not confident I could get us far at all. Certainly not safely. Not to mention that I can't really lift myself."

"Why not?" Hershel asked.

"It's a jarring experience, being dangled in mid-air. It makes my stomach queasy and messes up my concentration, which just makes things less stable in a terrible cycle," Mary said.

"So then, what's our strategy?" Vince asked.

In response Nick rose to his feet, dusted off the snow, and produced a pick along with a section of rope from his bag. "I'd say our strategy is climb like motherfuckers in hopes of making it home before Christmas."

After a moment of staring at each other the rest of the group pulled out their instruments and followed suit.

\* \* \*

To say the act of climbing a mountain was grueling would be like saying Genghis Khan had a mild penchant for empire expansion. It was cold, hellish, and hard, but as the five struggled up the mountain, they found it was doable. For the first time they were thankful for the months they had spent in gym. Without Coach George's constant conditioning they would have never had a chance at making viable progress. Proof of this was Hershel, who was forced to use some of his whiskey in the first half hour for fear his muscles would give out and he would go tumbling down. Each of them held this fear, but luckily it wasn't too steep at the mountain's base, and there were plateaus where rest could be acquired. On one such plateau they stopped midway through the day for a lunch of water, jerky, and despair. There was nowhere to go but up, though, so they bucked up and began climbing once more.

Even Alice found herself hugging the side of the mountain as they climbed higher. With each bit of escalation the wind grew stronger and colder. Gliding next to the rocks at least gave her some refuge from the wind's chilling bit. Admittedly she could have flown up to their next logical break stop and waited, but she wasn't confident they would find her once she departed. Besides, even if it wasn't steep, accidents could happen, and she wanted to be close by just in case.

The day wore on and progress grew slower. The mountain was getting steeper and their muscles were growing colder. There was a brief huddle during which they agreed to camp on the next viable rest stop they reached since it would be madness to try and keep going in the dark. Unfortunately, that spot was farther up than they'd expected, and by the time Roy hauled himself over an icy cliff, nearly everyone else was ready to collapse. Mary followed after him, then Vince. Alice floated over to stand with them, trying not to shiver despite herself. Nick was the last man to scale the side, rolling over and resting for a moment before pulling himself to his feet.

"Well," Vince said. "That sure suc-" A loud cracking sound interrupted Vince, coming from the edge they had just scaled. There was a moment of realization as Nick looked down to the source of the noise and saw it was coming from directly under his feet.

"Shit!" Nick managed to say as the ice they had mistaken for rock gave way and he went tumbling back into the open air.

## 68.

There are certain things a person is programmed to expect when falling to their death. Fear, of course. Also a bit of nausea as your stomach rises up. Some of the more metaphysically-inclined believers tell us to expect our lives to flash before our eyes. The one thing no one is ever really expecting, though, is what happened Nick. To be more precise, a pink-clad missile dropped from the heavens and sacked him in the gut.

"Ooof," Nick grunted as he was swung upward onto the same thin shoulder that had just lodged itself in his intestines.

"Not exactly a picnic for me either," Alice replied, slowing her decent gently.

"Good hit," Nick cracked out, trying to right his perceptions in the blitz of snow and wind assaulting his senses.

"Not going to lie, I enjoyed the hell out of it," Alice chuckled. "Now give me your sunglasses."

"Why?"

"Why? Because I can't see shit and I'm the one driving. Oh, and you aren't getting any lighter, if you were wondering." Their progress downward had come to a stop and Alice was now pushing them upward with increasing momentum.

"Excellent point," Nick agreed, whipping off his shades and placing them in her hand. He would have been more contrary in different circumstances, but being fireman-carried in mid-air was enough to make even him agreeable.

"You might want to hold on," Alice cautioned him. "I've never tried to fly with two people before."

"What's wrong with slow, safe rise?"

"I can't hold you that long. My grip is already slipping," Alice admitted.

Nick reached down and grabbed her belt firmly without another word.

"Watch the hands," Alice snapped and then they were off. Nick might have described the feeling as exhilarating had his life not been in jeopardy. Instead the only words that came to mind were "hellish," "wild," and

"horrificing." It turned out Alice didn't just float like an abandoned balloon; she cut through the air with shocking speed and hurtled toward her objective. An objective that was difficult to see even with eye protection, primarily due to her cargo severely compromising her maneuverability. Her grip was steadily deteriorating, but she didn't even dream of readjusting. This was all she had; if she couldn't find a place to land then Nick was going to fall.

Then, mercifully, something pierced the white world surrounding them. A bright burst of flame from thirty feet up and to their left. Alice never hesitated, adjusting her course and barreling toward it. She had no hope of sticking a safe landing with both herself and Nick, so she slowed down as much as she could before arriving, then yelled at the top of her lungs.

"CATCH!"

"What!" Nick shrieked as she flipped him over her shoulder and left him falling through the air once more. This drop was shorter as he felt an invisible force wrap around him and control his descent. Despite the wind and his naked eyes, he saw Alice pull up short a few feet away, plowing into the snow-covered ground with her feet but managing to stop before she hit the mountain's side. As his own feet finally made contact with the sweet, sweet ground, he turned to face his second savior.

"I thought you couldn't lift people."

"I said it's hard, not impossible," Mary corrected.

"Holy crap, are you okay?" Vince asked, fumbling over to check on his friend. He paused when he arrived, then cocked his head quizzically.

"Huh. I never knew you had brown eyes."

\* \* \*

"I am going to cut those two into pieces while they sleep," Nick grumbled as they huddled around the heat provided by a small can of Sterno.

"Good to see that Ethics class really paying off," Vince quipped.

"At least they gave us tents," Hershel said optimistically. Roy had turned back into Hershel a few minutes after Nick and Alice's spectacular air show. They'd taken the time to pull out the pop tents, anchor them down, and then break into jerky and gather by the small can of heat.

"I don't think they'll let us die out here," Alice said.

"Because they're such awesome guys?" Nick asked.

"No, because my dad has more money and political influence than some countries and I'm his only child," Alice explained.

"You never mentioned that before," Vince said.

"It was never a comforting thought before," Alice pointed out. "If I'd said it at a different time it would just sound bitchy."

"It still sounded a little bitchy," Nick said.

Alice punched him in the arm in response. "Next time I'm letting you fall."

"Yeesh, okay, I'm sorry, I'm sorry. Thought a little levity could lighten the mood."

"Well, it is making me laugh," Mary said, giggling softly. "Bodily harm to Nick is always good humor."

"Huzzah, I've finally found my role in the group," Nick said.

"I thought you had smart-ass pretty much on lock down since day one," Hershel told him.

"Seconded," Vince agreed.

"That went without saying," Nick added. "Anyway, enough about me. Let's get back to Alice being a secret millionaire."

"It wasn't really a secret," Alice defended. "I told you about him a little when we did our project. It just isn't something I wanted to bring up. I mean, come on, except for Nick, I don't know anything about your families either. Maybe you're secret millionaires, too."

"My parents are optometrists," Mary said. "They're well off, but hardly millionaires."

"So neither of them had any abilities?" Hershel asked.

"Only a talent for asking people to read off charts. Me being a Powered was a total shocker for them."

"How'd they take it?" Vince asked.

"Not bad. Better than when I decided to live in the woods by myself," Mary said.

"My mom rolled with it really well," Hershel said. "She took to it like she found out she had another son. She never batted an eye about the fact that



I couldn't control when I changed."

"How about your dad?" Nick probed.

"He... well, he left a few years ago, but it wasn't because of me or Roy. Hell, he's the one who taught Roy how to fight. Roy got a lot more unruly after Dad was gone, though. He used to be kind of nice." Hershel cleared his throat and Vince took the cue to pull attention away from his friend.

"What about you, Nick? Alice said she knew about your family, but we don't."

"My parents died when I was a baby. I was raised by my mom's sister, Ms. Pips. Not much else to tell. You?"

"I never met my biological parents," Vince said. "I was given up for adoption at birth. Things went okay for a little while, then my power showed up and... well, there aren't a lot of foster families out there who can cope with someone as 'special needs' as I was. So when I was six I gave up and ran away."

"Wait, I've heard you talk about your dad before," Hershel said skeptically.

Vince nodded. "I call him my dad, because he was. Just not biologically. He found me that first week. I doubt I would have made it without his help. He was a vagrant, too, so he took me in and showed me the ropes. For some reason my power never flared out of control around him. I wondered if he had an ability of his own, but he always denied it. He taught me about life, taught me how to fight even though he only had his right arm, and helped me learn to live on the rails. He died in an explosion when I was thirteen."

"I'm so sorry," Alice said.

"It's okay; it was five years ago. I've made peace with it," Vince assured her.

"But... wait, that was when you were thirteen. You joined us when you were eighteen; what did you do in between?" Hershel asked.

"I kept wandering. Dad taught me how, and it seemed safer than staying in one place or getting too close to people. With him gone it was too dangerous," Vince explained.

"So you've been alone for five years?" Alice asked, hoping to be corrected.

"I wouldn't say alone. I met people, even made friends here and there. But in the way you mean it, yeah, I guess I was," Vince told her.

"Okay, I think the rough childhood award definitely goes to Vince," Nick said, breaking the dark mood that had slipped over them.

Alice rewarded him with another punch for his efforts. "Be sensitive, you dick."

"It's fine," Vince said, waving her off. "Ancient history. Besides, I think it's safe to say we all went through our tough spots."

"I'm inclined to count this as one of them," Mary noted.

"Agreed," Vince said. "We should get some sleep now that it's dark, though. No sense in wasting any daylight tomorrow. Does anyone know how to turn off the fire?"

"More trouble than it's worth to try and relight it," Mary said. "Just absorb it so we can use the heat later."

"Can do," Vince said, draining the can of the remaining fire. "See you guys in the morning."

## 69.

The thing about climbing mountains is that the first day is pretty much the easiest. From then on you're dealing with sore muscles, thinning air, and often-increasing steepness. The five of them made it to the third day with their free-climbing strategy, but a couple of close calls forced them to regroup and examine their options. None of them had any experience on a mountain; however, they did grasp the basic concepts of ropes and hooks, so after some debate and the working out of a few details, the strategy was officially changed.

Now they had Alice fly up ahead of them and secure several hooks, linking the rope and then attaching it to her friends at the lower altitude. It took several tries for her to get the hang of it, but by the time they stopped to rest at the end of day four she was able to work reliably and with increasing speed. That was good, because communication was breaking down.

After that first night they'd been too tired to really converse when they camped. It had turned into slinging out the tents, stuffing down some food, and collapsing within. If the day had been particularly hellish they might eat around a can of Sterno, but those were limited and it was mutually understood that they were to be used sparingly. Vince was another asset they tapped for warmth, huddling around him on breaks for a quick wave of precious, precious heat.

They were cold, they were miserable, and they were tired. They were making progress, though. On the fifth day, Hershel drank the last of his whiskey for Roy's final appearance. Vince developed a nosebleed midway through the day and Alice's head began to throb in pain. They pressed as far as they could, but they could feel themselves slowing down. When the light began to fade they were forced to camp, though they hadn't gotten as far as on previous days.

"So I hate to be the buzzkill," Nick said as they huddled around the final can of Sterno. "But what happens if we miss the deadline tomorrow?"

"I don't think they'll let us die, but... I guess maybe we fail?" Alice said uncertainly, her fingers gently rubbing her temples.

"Which entails... what, exactly?" Hershel interjected.

"I think it means we're done," Vince replied somberly. "They're testing us, just like George and Persephone. I imagine failure here has the same result."

"But that's not fair! We've passed all the same standards as everyone else. Why would they hold us some ridiculously higher standard?" Hershel asked.

"Because we're different," Nick replied automatically. "We're not like everyone else, so it makes sense that we have different criteria to fulfill."

"They warned me to expect it when I took them up on the offer to enroll in Lander," Mary agreed.

"Me too," Vince said.

"Ditto," Alice chimed in.

"Roy and me, too," Hershel said, dejectedly. "I just never thought they meant this."

"Wish you hadn't taken the offer for Lander?" Alice asked him.

"Not even a little bit. Yeah, this sucks, but I've had so much fun these last few months. I never knew what it was like to feel normal in any group of people. With Alex and you guys, though, I'm not the freak. I'm just another Super," Hershel admitted.

"There are days I think that's the real reason they gave us the offer," Vince speculated. "They wanted us to have a chance to see what regular Supers felt like, so we could blend in later on."

"Maybe so," Mary agreed.

"Not that it will matter much if we can't finish this mountain tomorrow," Nick pointed out.

"We don't know that," Alice countered.

"But we have excellent grounds to suspect it," Nick shot back.

"Then there's only one option," Vince said, a surprising resolve echoing through his voice. "We don't fail."

The others were silent for a moment. Vince was so cheerful and easygoing that they often let it slip their mind how determined he could be when the occasion demanded it. It could take them back a step.

"I hate to point this out, but you guys realize tomorrow all you'll have is me, right? And I doubt I can climb as fast as Roy," Hershel said.

"Maybe not, but you're fresh," Mary said encouragingly. "Roy's done

all the labor, so I bet you can easily keep up with our worn out bodies."

Hershel was about to voice his own lack on surety in just that subject, but the looks on his ragged friends' faces made him think better of it. Instead he took a cue from Vince and mustered up his resolve.

"I will."

\* \* \*

If the other days were hard, the sixth day was impossible. They had to move fast to make up for lost time, and as such didn't permit themselves as much time for breaks. That strategy showed its downside within the first three hours as sore hands struggled to hold grips and weakening spirits began to falter. Each of them wanted nothing more than to slide down the mountain and collapse into a pile of sweet, exhausted sleep. Instead they kept going up. They halted briefly for lunch and a Vince warm-up, then got right back at it. The day wore on, and as the sun began to descend, hope trickled out of them. If it was dark they were done. The cold and wind made it too dangerous, and that's ignoring the problem of seeing their way without light. With Alice placing hooks there were no free hands to hold flashlights.

Hershel was puffing hard as the shadows grew longer. He hadn't been given several months of intense conditioning; he'd let Roy handle that. The only thing that kept him moving was the knowledge that this was only a sixth of the torture the others had endured. As he cursed under his breath and hoisted himself another few inches, Hershel made two promises to himself. The first was that he was going to start getting himself into passable shape, and the other was that he was going to start carrying a bigger emergency flask of whiskey.

Vince's nose was bleeding freely again, so he tore off a few scraps of cloth, stuffed them in his nostrils, and let it be. At this altitude there was nothing else to be done; the only way out was at the top.

Mary and Nick were holding together okay, though Nick had several close calls and was able to save himself only thanks to his excellent reflexes. Mary was able to press herself close to the rocky surface of the mountain and a few times actually held herself up telepathically so she could rest her aching hands. It was dizzying and dangerous but an assessed risk she deemed to be worth it.

Alice's head was still pounding, but she did her best not to show it. She pulled free some hooks from below her team and flew up higher to reattach them. They were coming up on a cliff that jutted out slightly,

blocking the view above. It would be tricky to climb so Alice decided to attach the hooks on the plateau the cliff would be concealing. She floated up past the side, blinked, and moved up several more feet to confirm what she was seeing. When she was absolutely sure she dropped back down and yelled to the others.

"The top! We're almost at the top!" With her news delivered, Alice flew back up to re-secure the hooks.

As for the other four, while weariness and fear can do a lot to drag down the human spirit, suddenly finding out your goal is in sight can kick the shit out of nearly every negative feeling you've got. Such was the case as the cries from their aching muscles and cold bodies were no longer nearly as relevant as the sense of almost being done. They hurled themselves upward with the last of their strength, leaving nothing behind in their quest to finish. Within half an hour the last of them, Hershel, was pulling himself over the side and flopping onto the cold, but level, ground.

They rested for a brief moment before dragging themselves vertical to complete the final task. It was Nick who found the phone, using his power and picking a direction randomly. He pulled the device from the snow and removed its waterproof cover. He glanced at his teammates and waited. Then he stepped forward and handed the phone to Alice.

"Make the call," Nick told her.

"Why me?"

"Because I'd be dead, and none of us would be up here, without you. Now call those bastards and let's go home," Nick said.

Alice nodded and accepted the phone. She punched a few buttons, and in mere seconds a familiar voice greeted her.

"Hello," Mr. Transport said placidly.

"We did it," Alice said, her voice weary and cracked, but her tone full of pride.

## 70.

"We should all pitch in, pool our money, and have those two killed," Nick suggested, soaking in the heat and the comfort of the common room couch.

"Nick, I'm right here," Mr. Transport said. All five students had been given a chance to take hot showers and unwind a bit, now they were meeting to talk about the test at Mr. Transport's request.

"I know," Nick said happily, not even bothering to glance at him. "I believe in fair warning."

"Now look, I know it wasn't an enjoyable experience, but it was necessary," Mr. Transport explained. He was met with dark glares and grumbling. "Listen, it's Christmas Eve and I'm sure you all want to get home to your families, so we don't have to talk about this now. Just promise you'll take the rest of the break to really think about what you learned on that mountain. About yourself, about each other, about everything."

"I promise," Mary said, not quite enthusiastically. The others merely nodded in agreement.

"Non-verbal is good enough for me. Whenever you're ready go get your stuff and I'll drop you off at home," Mr. Transport offered.

"Pass," Alice said waving him off. "I'll take my car. I'm only two hours up the road."

"I can take both you and your car in a span of seconds," Mr. Transport pointed out.

"Still no. I just spent six days on a damn mountain, I'm looking forward to a nice, relaxing drive," Alice reiterated.

"Fair enough," Mr. Transport said, putting up his hands. "When anyone else is ready, I'll be waiting in here."

\* \* \*

"Hershel!" Mrs. Daniels yelled, flying out of her house to meet her son walking up the driveway. "It's been too long, dear," she said, giving him a strong hug.

"I missed you, too, Mom," Hershel managed to squeak out as she squeezed his lungs.

"My, look at you," she said, releasing her death grip and taking a step back. "You must be at least two inches taller than when you left."

"You think?"

"I know my son, don't I? Come on inside. I'll fix up some dinner and afterward we can get the tape measure if you don't believe me."

"Sounds like a plan," Hershel agreed, dragging his bag inside and depositing it by the door. He'd unpack later; for now he was just happy to be home.

The house seemed just as he remembered it, though now there was a Christmas tree by the fireplace. Underneath were several presents, some wrapped in green paper and others wrapped in red. The red would be for Roy, the green for him, same as it had been for years and years. A spicy scent wafted through the house. His mom would be working on several dishes for lunch tomorrow. On Christmas they went to Hershel's grandmother's house and met up with the rest of his family. Hershel realized that this was the first year he would be able to enjoy himself at that gathering and not worry about Roy butting in. Still, he might change later in the day. It was Christmas for Roy, too, after all.

"So," his mother said, interrupting Hershel's internal reverie. "Tell me about college. Have you met any nice girls?"

Hershel smiled in spite of himself and went over to the kitchen table. He took a seat in usual spot and basked in the familiarity for a moment before dealing with his mother's question.

"Well, there is this girl in my dorm..."

\* \* \*

Vegas was cold, but that could hardly be blamed on the season. It was a desert: those were hot in the day and cold in the evening. Nick walked up the familiar landscape of the strip and picked out the lighted monstrosity he called home. One good thing about this town: an unaccompanied minor with a suitcase didn't even draw a second glance as he walked into the lobby of a casino/hotel and strode right past the reception desk. Nick would greet everyone soon, but first he wanted to go up to his room and change. He was still dressed as the Lander student, and that wasn't an image that belonged here. His only hope was that the sunglasses and different wardrobe would keep anyone from recognizing him. He should have known better.

Nick made it to the elevators and punched the up button. The elevators



were gold in color and the hall was faux marble. It was ostentatious, but with a touch of class, just like the rest of Ms. Pips' establishment. It didn't quite give him a sense of being at home; however, it was an environment he was comfortable in. For Nick, that was more or less the same thing. There was an audible ding as the doors swooshed open and Nick took a step back to accommodate anyone exiting. The elevator turned out to hold only one other occupant, a bald man wearing a dark suit. Nick sighed and stepped on board. He knew perfectly well this man wasn't planning to get off.

"Good to see you, Gerry," Nick said evenly. He would greet his former wrangler more enthusiastically later in the evening. For now, though, there were cameras everywhere and it was a poor habit indeed to start showing fondness to anyone.

"You look good, Campbell," Gerry replied. He leaned forward and punched a few buttons on the pad. The elevator began rising to a floor inaccessible to regular guests. "I wanted to let you know that Ms. Pips is currently overseeing a high-stakes poker game, but she should be on hand for lunch tomorrow."

"They do put on a hell of a spread for Christmas," Nick recalled.

"Of course. We can't have any of our clients regretting their decision to spend the holidays handing us their money," Gerry said. "Anyway, she'll be around tomorrow; tonight you're on your own, though. I had a couple of your suits cleaned and pressed, and I alerted the staff to expect your return."

"I have missed the people," Nick said.

"You've missed the girls," Gerry shot, a bit of slyness in his voice.

"Never as much as they miss me," Nick said with a smile.

The elevator dinged and opened on a plush hallway. The carpet was red and the trim of the walls was gold. There were very few rooms in this hallway because up here the designers hadn't been concerned with cramming in as many as they could fit. This was the level that few would ever see and fewer would ever stay in. Nick stepped off and began heading down to his room. He stopped after a few steps, noting Gerry hadn't exited with him.

"I've got some things to do," Gerry said in response to Nick's glance backward. "If you'd like me to catch you up on things we can meet in the usual place around two."

"Sounds good," Nick agreed. The usual place would be a restaurant a few streets over from the strip where he and Gerry had hamburgers and hung

out. It was one of the few places away from Ms. Pips' direct area of influence, and likely Nick's favorite spot in the world.

Nick swiped a card at the door and entered his suite. Sure enough, Gerry had laid out a couple of suits on the bed. He always remembered every detail, a habit he had worked very hard to ingrain in Nick as well. Still, Nick's first concern wasn't just with changing his clothes. He whipped off his sunglasses and tossed them on a dresser. He then shed the rest of his Lander ensemble and hopped over to the shower. Admittedly he had taken a shower less than an hour before, but that had been all about heat and necessity. This was about re-centering. Nick always found a shower the best tool for wiping away a character and coming back to himself.

Half an hour later Nicholas Campbell emerged. He promptly dressed, wearing a deep purple button-down shirt with no tie beneath a perfectly tailored black suit. He styled his sandy hair with a tussled look and adorned himself with only one piece of jewelry, a silver wristwatch. He frowned slightly when he noticed there were tan lines on his face from those ridiculous glasses and made a mental note to visit a spray bed as soon as possible. All decoration and preparation complete, Nicholas paused only to give the sunglasses a dirty look before striding out the door.

\* \* \*

"You're sure you want me to drop you here?" Mr. Transport asked again, just to be certain.

"Positive," Mary assured him, enjoying the sound of leaves crunching beneath her feet and the sticky smell of pine in the air.

"Don't you want to see your family?"

"I'll see them tomorrow," Mary told him. "I wanted to spend one night at home, though." She was already walking toward her trailer, small bag swinging in hand as she surveyed the spots that could use repair.

"Whatever makes you happy, I suppose. Merry Christmas," Mr. Transport wished her, then was gone.

Mary finished her tour of the trailer, coming back to its entrance and unlocking the door. It was cold inside, but a few minutes after she turned on the generator the whole place would be thoroughly warmed. Besides, in comparison to her past week she could barely classify it as chilly. Mary carefully opened her bag and tenderly removed a small brown bear, setting him on the counter.

"It's good to be home, don't you think, No?"

No was his usual, stoically silent self.

\* \* \*

"So good to have you home, Ms. Adair," the maid said, greeting Alice at the door and taking her bag.

"Thank you, Greta. Tell Francis the rest of my luggage is in the car. Is my father home?"

"He'll be in China until the end of the week," Greta told her. "But he's promised to come home in time to see you before you go back to school."

"Of course he will," Alice sighed, knowing it was fifty/fifty at best that she would see her father during this break. That might have been for the best, though; she wasn't sure what she would say to him. She'd never really had a grasp of what to talk about with him anyway, but at least before she'd known the right steps and decorum. After her semester at Lander, though, she didn't find the prospect as appealing. Alice had slowly been dropping out of the habit of shying away from real interaction and using polite falsities. She was finding she liked the life she led this way far more than the other. Daddy wouldn't approve, though.

Alice made her way up the marble staircase to her wing of the house. Most of the servants were off for the holiday, so she'd have the house more or less to herself with the exception of Greta, Francis, a few chefs, and some additional support staff. Normally she preferred it this way: it was less lonely to be actually alone than to be surrounded by people and still be by oneself. As her steps echoed down the empty hallway and she pushed open the oak doors to her pink-themed bedroom, it occurred to that she'd become far more accustomed to the bustle of Melbrook.

Alice laid down on her bed and stared up at the ceiling. There were paintings adorning her walls along with a picture or two of her father. The only real photograph she held dear was on her bedside table, though: a photo of a beautiful blonde woman with an infectious smile. Alice had digital copies of it, of course, but there was still something special about the original. Alice rolled over on her side and stared at the woman for a few minutes, wondering for the billionth time how different this moment in her life would be if that woman were still a part of it. There would be someone waiting for her, certainly. A hug, some conversation, and possibly even a meal prepared out of love rather than obligation. Perhaps Daddy would even be here as well if that woman was around to wrangle him in.

Alice had long ago mastered the art of crying silently, so not one sob echoed through the empty catacombs of her mansion.

\* \* \*

"Thanks again for bringing me out here," Vince said as he and Mr. Transport walked along a snow-covered dirt path.

"I'm not exactly certain where 'here' is. We've walked a good way from the city," Mr. Transport pointed out.

"We're almost there," Vince assured him.

For a few brief moments Mr. Transport thought back to Nick's death threat jokes and wondered just how much Vince had disliked the mountain test. Then he mentally snapped himself back to reality and realized while one of his charges might eventually kill him, Vince was easily the least likely candidate on that list. Well, after Hershel.

They turned down another path and pushed their way through some brush. This time, though, the scenery opened up and Mr. Transport found himself staring at a set of lightly snow-dusted train tracks. In front of him was a sheer cliff about sixty feet high that looked down on the scene. The tracks seemed to run back in the direction of town, though they were clearly a long time out of use. Mr. Transport was about to question once again precisely where they were; however, the sight of Vince's face paused his words. It wasn't sad, per se. Exposed would be a better word. Soundlessly Vince reached into his pocket and pulled out a small gold watch. He began winding it carefully, a few clicks at a time.

"My dad gave me this watch for my thirteenth foundday. He said I never had to worry about stealing power from it, because it relied on being wound," Vince said, his voice somewhere far away.

"Foundday?" Mr. Transport asked.

"I didn't know my real birthday since I ran away at such a young age, so we just celebrated the day he found me instead," Vince explained.

"That sounds very... festive," Mr. Transport said uncertainly.

"It was. I know how bad it sounds, living on the rail, scrounging for food, but it was fun. It was nice to have somewhere I belonged," Vince said.

"Not to overstep my bounds, but it seems to me you have found that once more. And I don't think any of your fellow Melbrook residents would disagree with me."

Vince let out a small laugh. "I guess you have a point. I think that would make my dad happy."

"I'm sure it would," Mr. Transport agreed.

There was a gust of wind across the tracks and the sedentary snowflakes bounded about for a few elegant swirls before settling back onto the cold, rusted steel.

"This is where he died," Vince said, not as much to Mr. Transport but to the world at large. "I try to come by here at least once a year. Usually around Christmas if I can. There weren't any recognizable remains of anyone from the explosion, so there's no grave. Just... this spot."

Mr. Transport stayed silent. A few minutes passed by and Vince finished winding his watch. He flipped open the cover, checked the time, then snapped it shut.

"Thank you, Mr. Transport. I know it's cold and wet out here. We can go back to Melbrook now."

"There's no hurry. I'm not expected anywhere until a few hours from now," Mr. Transport told him.

Vince nodded his understanding. A fresh crop of snow was beginning to drift down upon them, some of it clinging to his hair, changing its appearance to more white than silver. Mr. Transport resisted the urge to shiver. He wouldn't be showing any discomfort until Vince was ready to leave on his own.

"Merry Christmas, Mr. Transport," Vince said over the soft winds.

"Merry Christmas, Vince."

## 71.

"So I'm the last one then?" Hershel asked.

"Correct," Mr. Transport confirmed. "Alice again elected to drive back, Nick did the same, Vince never left and Mary requested pickup yesterday."

"Nick drove back? He doesn't have a car."

"I suspect that changed over the break," Mr. Transport said. "Are you ready to go?"

"Almost; I just have to run upstairs and grab one thing," Hershel said, darting up those steps with vigor.

Hershel and Mr. Transport had been sitting in the Daniels' living room. Christmas break would be over in a few days and this was the date Hershel had submitted to be picked up. He was excited and nervous. It would be great to be back at Lander, but time spent there could hardly be considered relaxing or predictable. A few weeks at home had left him restless, though, and he was anxious to see his friends once more.

"Thank you for bringing back Hershel," Mrs. Daniels said, walking into the room and setting down a tray of cookies. "It saves us quite a bit on airfare."

"Glad to do it," Mr. Transport said politely.

"Well, please help yourself to some sweets anyway. I appreciate what you and the other man have done for my boys all year," Mrs. Daniels said with a smile. She proffered her hand and Mr. Transport willingly accepted. He was surprised, though; he had expected a delicate shake but instead was treated to a surprisingly firm grip choking his fingers.

"Um, Mrs. Daniels," Mr. Transport tried to begin.

"I'd also like you to know Hershel told me about your little extracurricular test on the mountain, and I am not altogether pleased with my children being put in danger," Mrs. Daniels said, cutting him off.

"I can assure you they were always under observation and never in any real danger," Mr. Transport explained hastily.

"And I can assure you that had better be the case. I accept that there is some risk of injury when entering the HCP, but I find abandoning five

children on a mountain very unacceptable," Mrs. Daniels said in a calm, even tone.

"Noted," Mr. Transport said, trying in vain to wriggle his fingers free.

"Please do," Mrs. Daniels said, releasing her grip. "I may be a normal person; however, trust me when I say that being a mother is a power all its own. I think we understand one another now, don't we, Mr. Transport?"

"Implicitly."

"Sorry it took a few minutes," Hershel said, descending the staircase with a duffel bag slung over his shoulder.

"Nothing to worry about, sweetie," Mrs. Daniels said in a cheerful tone. "Mr. Transport and I were just discussing how happy you seem to be at Lander."

"I am really am," Hershel said. "I miss you, though, Mom."

"Oooh that's my boy," Mrs. Daniels said, wrapping her son in a tight hug. "You don't worry about me, though. You go on and have a great time. I'll see you in a month at Parents' Weekend."

"Awesome," Hershel said, finishing the hug and walking over to Mr. Transport. "Well, I'm ready when you are."

"Take care, dear," Mrs. Daniels told him. "And Mr. Transport, be sure to take care of my sons."

Mr. Transport nodded his understanding and, to his credit, managed not to gulp. It took some effort, though, which considering he was looking at a middle-aged woman a good foot shorter than he made him feel not so masculine. He didn't really rush off, but he didn't dawdle either as he thought of their destination and activated his power.

\* \* \*

"I still feel like it's stealing," Vince's voice said as Mr. Transport and Hershel materialized in front of them. Vince and Nick were in the common lounge, watching television and clearly having some sort of debate.

"It isn't stealing. They offered it up to someone who could fulfill a set of specified conditions. I fulfilled those conditions so everybody wins," Nick defended. His had just finished his sentence when he became aware the room had suddenly doubled its occupants in the span of less than a second. "Oh, hey, Hershel."

"Hershel!" Vince said, jumping up from the couch and greeting his friend with a hug. "It's good to see you, man. How was your break?"

"Lots of fun," Hershel replied, setting down his bag. "I saw some old friends, got to eat home-cooking, and just freaking relax. Yours?"

"Not bad. I stayed here for the most part. Tried to keep the same training schedule so the first one back wouldn't destroy me. Not much else, really," Vince said.

"I did something cool," Nick volunteered.

"It wasn't cool," Vince corrected him. "It was immoral and unethical."

"What'd you do?" Hershel asked.

"I won a car," Nick said with a dopey grin.

"You didn't 'win' a car. You used your power on a slot machine to make the right combination come up. You cheated and stole a car," Vince shot back.

"Also I did this," Nick said. "Pretty much for the last few days. Turns out Vince will hang on to shit like this tighter than a miser to his last dollar bill."

"Because you haven't made it right," Vince pointed out.

"Hate to break it to you, buddy, but there isn't really a process for giving back a car you won off a slot machine. Want to know why? Because it would be batshit insane," Nick told him.

"Glad to see nothing has changed," Hershel laughed with a shake of his head. "So we've still got a couple of days off left. Any big plans?"

"Tomorrow we go see which class we qualified for and what the rankings for the finals were," Vince said. "Nothing on the docket today, though."

"Actually, that is incorrect," Mr. Numbers said, stepping into the room from the kitchen. "Now that you have all returned we need to discuss your test."

Mr. Transport's fingers involuntarily twinged with pain.

"Killjoy," Nick said.

"It shouldn't take all day," Mr. Transport said encouragingly. "Plus,



once it's over you still have a day left for fun."

"Or for plotting your eventual murder in the event we don't find your reasoning for that whole stunt satisfactory," Nick tossed out.

"You'd need far more than a day to conceive a plan with any chance of working," Mr. Numbers informed him.

"Heard and remembered," Nick replied.

"Don't be such a drama queen," Mary said as the door to the girls' side opened, allowing her and Alice to emerge. "I could hear your squabbling all the way in my room."

"Hey Mary, hey Alice," Hershel greeted them.

"Hi, Hershel," Mary said with a soft smile. Alice merely greeted him with a directed nod.

"Now that we're all here, let's get started," Mr. Numbers told them.

## 72.

"I learned never to stand too close to Mr. Transport," Nick said, kicking things off.

"I'm actually going to second that one," Alice agreed.

"Very funny," Mr. Transport said. "Be serious, though. What you took from the test is almost as important as the test itself."

There was a pause of silence before Mary's voice spoke up.

"I learned that being Super doesn't mean I can do *anything*," she admitted. "I've been able to handle everything so easily now that I can control my power, but none of it really helped me on the mountain."

"You helped save me," Nick pointed out.

"And Alice helped save us all by securing the ropes as we scaled the mountain," Mary replied. "My point was that when I was Powered, I always assumed Supers could just do anything. I was wrong."

"Yeah," Vince agreed. "The only people with really useful powers were Alice and Roy."

"That's because of the environment, though," Alice said. "If we'd been stuck in a volcano then your absorption ability would have been indispensable."

"Which brings up another point," Hershel said. "None of us is the best in every situation. In fact, there are probably situations where four of us would be totally screwed without our fifth friend."

"I guess that's why so many Heroes form teams," Vince speculated.

"Which, for those of you still wondering, is the realization we were supposed to come to, right?" Nick asked, looking over at Mr. Numbers.

"No comment," Mr. Numbers answered.

"We were supposed to realize why it's useful for established Heroes to form teams?" Hershel asked uncertainly.

"We were supposed to realize that we are a team," Vince explained to him, catching on. "They wanted us to depend on one another, to lean on one another, and to save one another. They wanted us to work as a unit rather than a set of individuals."

"But why? I mean, we more or less did our own thing last semester and got through without issues," Alice said.

"Because it's going to get harder," Mary told her. "We've done well so far, yes. However, we all are about ten to fifteen years behind everyone else in this program. They've spent a lifetime learning to use and control their powers while we're just scratching the surface."

"Funny thing for the number one rank on the girls' side to say," Nick pointed out.

"Yes, I did well. A lot of that was by surprise and luck, though. You were with me in the labyrinth fighting Gilbert. Did it seem like I would have won by myself?" Mary asked.

"Fair enough," Nick agreed.

"So what's the point here?" Vince asked. "That we suck alone?"

"That we should work together more, I think," Alice said. "That we're facing a very difficult obstacle, not unlike climbing a mountain, and that the only way we'll make it is if we work together and are ready to help and save one another."

Nick and Mary glanced at one another from their respective positions. They alone knew that while Alice was close, there was a whole other reason their caretakers had wanted to instill that team mentality. This was the point where they could steer the conversation to that logical conclusion, or cut things off and let the others believe it was done solely out of concern for their progress in the program.

"I think you're right, Alice," Mary agreed. "It makes the most sense. And it's true. We've got a long way left to go before we're Heroes, we'll need to start leaning on each other more as things get harder."

"It's a valid point," Vince concurred.

"True," Hershel said with a nod.

"Personally, I think they did it to kill us and cut open our bodies for science," Nick said. "But I guess encouraging us to work together is a possibility."

"So were we right?" Alice asked Mr. Transport.

"You took the lesson you took," Mr. Numbers said, answering before Mr. Transport had a chance to try. "Mr. Transport told you, the lesson you

take is as important as the test itself. There wasn't a right or wrong one, only the one you arrived at. I'll say this, though: you five turned a difficult experience into a positive learning opportunity."

"That makes my frostbite all the more bearable, thank you," Nick quipped.

"Don't be such a baby," Alice scolded him.

"I'm pretty sure of all the situations in life I get to bitch about, being abandoned in the freezing snow and told to climb a mountain is right up near the top," Nick shot back. "It's over, though, so can we finish this meeting already? I want to swing by the video store and see if they still have Christmas-themed horror movies out."

"Nice to know nothing changed over the holidays," Vince said with a finger pressed to his temple.

"I think we've got a good sense of what you took from our lesson," Mr. Transport said. "Enjoy the rest of your day. Don't forget to meet me here at ten tomorrow, though. I'm sure you'll all want to see which class you wound up in and how you did on the final."

"And now that will hang over my head all day," Alice said.

"You know what's good for that?" Nick asked.

"We all know you're going to say bad horror movies," Hershel told him.

"No, I wasn't," Nick told him.

"Fine, what then?" Hershel asked.

"Awesomely bad horror movies," Nick replied with a wide grin.

"You kids have fun," Mr. Transport said, rising to his feet. "We're going... anywhere that isn't here."

He and Mr. Numbers vanished, leaving the students finally alone and back together for the first time in several weeks.

"So, what kind of car did you win, anyway?" Hershel asked.

"Beetle," Nick told him.

"Stole," Vince corrected.

"Damn it," Alice groaned.

"Seriously, Hershel? They've been like this for days. Please don't reignite this crap when it dies," Mary said.

"My bad," Hershel said, putting up his hands.

"Okay, look Vince, you've been plugging away at me on this relentlessly and I haven't caved. Now, it's apparent we're bothering those around us. So how about we say that this is in an area of murky morality and just agree to disagree. You think I'm wrong, I think I'm right, and neither of us seems to have a shot at changing the other's mind," Nick said.

"Agreed," Vince said after a brief pause. "I still think you should give it back, though."

"I'm well aware," Nick told him. "Now, who wants to ride in my ill-gotten gains to the video store?"

## 73.

"Welcome to the halls of horror!" Nick declared as the guests walked into Melbrook.

"Good to see you, too, Weirdo," Sasha said, giving him a quick hug. Greetings were exchanged all around as Will, Jill, Julia, and Alex followed suit. After procuring a few choice cinematic classics, the Melbrook students had decided to see how many of their friends were back from break. As it turned out, the answer was all of them.

Vince appeared from the boys' side lounge, dragging in some extra chairs. Since there were so many people they'd elected to hold the movie marathon in the common room and thus needed to increase seating. He stopped and set down the four-legged burdens, then noticed everyone else had arrived. It was good to see them, with one being a bit more warmly appreciated than the others.

"Hey," Vince said, walking up to Sasha.

"Hey yourself," she replied.

"You look nice," he told her.

"Missed you, too," Sasha said with a slowly spreading smile.

"Yeah, this is totally comfortable for everyone else watching, just if you were wondering," Julia tossed out.

"Sorry," Vince said, blushing rapidly.

"Speak for yourself," Sasha said. "I'm not ashamed to say I missed my man."

"That's okay, we're ashamed enough for you," Nick tossed out. Alice punched him in the arm reflexively. "Damn it!" he swore.

"You'd think a guy as smart as you could handle a little pattern recognition," Mary pointed out.

"Real funny," Nick said, rubbing his arm. "I'm going to go set up the movie."

"Good timing," Hershel said. "The popcorn will be done in a couple of minutes. Anybody want a soda before we start?" A few people raised their hands, so Hershel bustled off to the kitchen.

Julia let out a sad sigh. "I was really hoping Roy would be around my first night back."

"Take a cold shower," Jill chided her. "I'm sure he'll show in a day or so."

"But I haven't seen him in weeks," Julia continued complaining.

"Man, you really don't get the point of a booty call buddy, do you?" Sasha asked.

"Psh, with Amber spending all her time out with the boyfriend and you two being prudes, someone has to be getting a little in that dorm," Julia said. "And it might as well be a little that is toned, fit, handsome, and skilled."

"I'm literally begging you here, please stop talking," Mary jumped in. "This is leading to mental images I'd really rather not have to deal with."

"Fine," Julia said, crossing her arms. "I'm still hoping he shows up."

"That's your prerogative, I suppose," Mary said. "Though personally I'm glad we get to spend some time with Hershel."

Vince had a feeling Hershel would very much wish he had been present for that particular statement.

"I've got the drinks," Hershel said, walking back into the room. "Popcorn will be done in thirty seconds."

"Which will be just in time, because we're about to watch *Mad Santa Massacre*," Nick said, twirling the remote in his hand.

"Joy. It will be just like our Halloween movie session all over again," Will said, speaking for the first time.

"Except this time it might be someone else who screams like a girl," Jill chuckled, throwing her arm around her twin.

"My device was more realistic than even I expected," Will said defensively. "Which is why it is being redesigned."

"Only you could take something back to the drawing board because it was too good," Jill told him.

A loud ding echoed through the room.

"And that's the popcorn," Hershel said. "Okay folks, time to get started."

\* \* \*

"It sounds as though they're hosting a kegger out there," Mr. Numbers noted as he and Mr. Transport sat at their kitchen table.

"They just got back from break. It is completely natural for them to rejoice in seeing their friends," Mr. Transport said.

"I never said it was unnatural. I merely insinuated it was annoying," Mr. Numbers pointed out. He took a long sip of tea from the steaming cup in front of him.

"You seem edgy," Mr. Transport noted.

"I just spent a full week with my mother," Mr. Numbers told him. "You'd find your nerves diminished in tolerance as well."

"I suppose that's fair," Mr. Transport acquiesced. "So how do you think they'll take discovering their classes tomorrow?"

"Perfectly well," Mr. Numbers said. "There aren't any big surprises after all. It's been clear from the beginning who had the talent for combat and whose skills lay in other areas."

"You're right. I'm just a little worried. There's always been a stigma of the combat Supers being more elite, more valuable. I'd hate for our students in alternative training to feel like they somehow failed to measure up."

"Be reasonable, Mr. Transport. They're just thankful not to be destroying buildings or drowning in a sea of errant thoughts. I sincerely doubt any of them will care if they are perceived as 'less cool' than their peers."

"My understanding is these programs are exceptionally competitive," Mr. Transport said. "It's not unreasonable to worry about how they'll cope with additional social pressure."

"We left them on a mountain in the middle of December. I'm confident they can handle quite a bit of pressure," Mr. Numbers said.

"True," Mr. Transport agreed. "I was impressed by the lessons they took from it. I thought for sure some would go down a negative path."

"I was more impressed that Mary and Nick decided not to reveal the whole reason we did it," Mr. Numbers said.

"Do you think that means they trust us?"

"I think it means they are giving us some metaphorical rope, to see



where our loyalties lie and what we do with our position over the group," Mr. Numbers informed him.

"Let's hope we live up to their standards," Mr. Transport commented.

"I'm less concerned with their standards and more concerned with the school's," said Mr. Numbers. "Things grow increasingly more difficult from this point on."

"Still, it would be nice if they knew we had their best interests at heart," Mr. Transport said.

Mr. Number resisted the urge to point out that this statement would be easier to demonstrate if it were actually true. Despite years of service, Mr. Transport still had a streak of idealism in him, and it was a trait Mr. Numbers had resolved to foster in his companion for as long as he could. He was amazed it had endured for these many years, though each year seemed to edge it closer towards its inevitable destruction.

"Indeed," Mr. Numbers said simply, turning his attention back to his tea.

\* \* \*

The lone figure stood outside the Melbrook dorm, obscured by darkness and hidden behind a tree. In the abundance of shadow it was difficult to make out a definite shape or the sex of the figure, only that it was watching the flicking lights from within intently. The figure stood there unwavering, confident its hiding place wouldn't be discovered. It waited for hours, watching until the hour grew late and the guests emptied out and returned to their respective dorms. It lingered on even after that, seemingly unwilling to abandon this place quite yet. Eventually it left its obscured position and moved quickly across the campus, sticking to the darkest patches to maintain its anonymity.

## 74.

“As I call your name and say your new training program, line up on the appropriate side of the gym,” Coach George bellowed. “Combat training to the right, alternative training to the left. Those of you with ranks that predetermine your class, please take your places now.” There was a soft scuffle as ten boys and ten girls took their appropriate positions at the right and left of the gym.

“Nervous?” Vince asked Alex as they milled together with the remainder of the freshman class. There were only eleven students left after the twenty predetermined ones had taken their spots.

“Very,” Alex admitted. “I mean, we fought hard, but then again we went down so easily against Selena.”

“You have nothing to be ashamed of,” Thomas said, joining the conversation. “You put forth a tremendous effort in our battle. It would be pure folly not to place you in combat training.”

“Castillo, Thomas. Combat,” Coach George’s booming voice announced to the gym.

“See you on the right,” Thomas said reassuringly before jogging over to take his side.

“Hunt, Tiffani. Alternative.” A girl with short blonde hair flipped out at the ends walked over to the left side of the gym.

“Riley, Adam. Combat.”

“Wells, Allen. Combat.”

“Belden, Camille. Alternative.” Vince perked up at this name, recognizing it as one of his saviors from Halloween, the one he still hadn’t managed to thank. She was difficult to notice in the crowd, but when she broke out to walk to the left side Vince wondered how he’d missed her before. She was diminutive, even shorter than Mary, with shoulder length hair so blonde it bordered on white. There was something familiar about her as well, though Vince couldn’t put his finger on it. He resolved himself to seek her out after this was over and thank her for the healing help.

“Reid, Gilbert. Combat.”

“Wilkins, Selena. Alternative.”

“Murray, Jill. Combat.”

Vince took a deep breath to settle his stomach. He and Alex were the only two left.

“Griffen, Alex. Combat.” Alex flashed Vince a thumbs up before heading over and joining the line on the right.

“And lastly, Reynolds, Vincent. Combat,” Coach George declared.

Vince let out a sigh and threw a smile on his face, heading over to the right side of the gym. Inside though, he felt a ball of worry knot itself tighter. A part of him had been hoping he would end up in alternative training so he wouldn’t have to keep fighting people. Now he had several years filled with fisticuffs to look forward to.

“We’ll be giving all of you your mid-term grades today in private; however, as promised, we’re now going to announce the top three longest survivors and the top three killers from the exam,” Coach George began. “The number three killer was Chad Taylor. Number two was Britney Fletcher, and number one was Selena Wilkins.”

There was a mumbling of confusion. Everyone knew who Chad was, but the other two weren’t prominent warriors, though Vince and Alex felt a bit better in knowing the girl who’d taken them out was the best on the field.

“As for survivors, number three was Tiffani Hunt. Number two was Shane DeSoto. As for number one, well, she was the only person to make it on both lists: Britney Fletcher.” Nick noticed the girl who’d taken out himself and Alice blushing slightly. Well, at least he knew the invisible girl’s name now.

“I’m sure some of you are looking up and down the combat row, trying to place the names other than Shane and Chad,” Coach George said to the assembled class. “Well, you’d better turn your heads to the left side of the gym, because that’s where you’ll find them. You see, those people who captured the top spots in both categories, they’re in alternative training. And they kicked ninety percent of your asses.”

Coach Persephone took a step forward. “There is a perception among many that Heroes specializing in combat are the best. That’s true, in that they are the best at combat. Keep in mind that few criminals are so thoughtful as to arrange a bare-knuckle brawl in a secluded location where you can prove to them your superiority. More often than not skills like stealth, planning, and improvisation are far more useful. To those of you on the combat side of the room, most of you were likely hoping to end up in this training course. You

feel it's the better option, and in certain cases you're correct. Don't forget this lesson, though: just because someone is physically weaker than you doesn't mean they aren't a very real threat. You're dismissed for today. We'll see you in class tomorrow."

The lines broke as students began scattering in their own directions. Vince began crossing the gym to thank Camille, but his arm was grabbed halfway there.

"Reynolds," Coach George said, holding him in place. "You need to come by my office sometime before gym tomorrow."

"For what?" Vince asked.

"Let's call it part of your probationary requirements for half-assing it with your power," Coach George told him. George released Vince's arm and the silver-haired youth headed off in his original direction. Unfortunately, Camille had vanished during the brief discussion. Vince knew what she looked like now at least, so he was confident he could thank her next time.

Vince headed off to the changing room, wondering what requirement Coach George was going to give him. Since the last time a subject had taken him down this path had resulted in he and his friends being stuck on a mountain, he was understandably concerned. Still, it couldn't be that bad, could it?

"Hey man, what's with the long face?" Nick asked as he emerged from the locker area in his above-ground clothes.

"Nothing," Vince said, shaking off his concern. "So what are we doing with our last day of pre-class freedom?"

"Cocaine and strippers," Nick replied. Vince simply raised an eyebrow in response. "Fine, fine, we'll think of something else. Let's go rally the troops. Buzzkill."

Vince nodded his agreement and the two set off to actively waste some time.

## 75.

Vince knocked hesitantly on Coach George's office door. It was during his visiting hours, so he should be there, but Vince still felt a bit out of place. Nick was organizing a putt-putt outing for the group to do on its last day of break, but it would be another few hours before they departed and Vince had ultimately decided he would rather find out what Coach George wanted now rather than put it off for a day.

"Come in," Coach George hollered from the other side.

Vince turned the handle and walked in, taking in a more comprehensive view of the small office than last time. There were various degrees along the walls, as well as a multitude of pictures. Some were very old, but many seemed recent. The contents of these photographs were completely varied, with no common theme or person spanning them all.

The actual desk took up a significant portion of the room, and it was literally covered in papers. Vince wasn't sure how anyone could find anything in that enormous sprawl of pages. Sitting atop that mess though was something even more surprising. A car battery.

"Reynolds, glad you made it early," Coach George said from behind the desk. "Take a seat."

"Um, okay," Vince said uncertainly. "Why did you want to see me?"

"Because I'm adding something to your diet," Coach George told him.

"I'm not sure I understand."

"You keep yourself stocked with a little fire by draining lighters, right?" Coach George asked.

"Yes, sir."

"Well, I saw what you did during the mid-term, when you drained your weapon and blasted Castillo with electricity. That was impressive."

"Thank you," Vince said, struggling for a moment to figure out who Castillo was before remembering it was Thomas' last name.

"So impressive, in fact, that I decided you need to add it to your training regiment," Coach George continued. "Hence I brought you a snack." He patted the car battery.

“You want me to drain the battery? But I already keep some fire in reserve,” Vince said.

“So you can’t hold more than one form of energy at the same time?” Coach George asked.

“No, I can hold as many as I want. At least, that’s been my experience so far. I was referring to the talk we had last semester, about me not wanting to have too much in case I lost control,” Vince explained.

“Listen Reynolds, I’m more than meeting you halfway here. I’m cutting you more slack than I’ve given anyone in a very long time. I’m still your teacher, though, and I would be remiss in my duties if I let you get by without mastering all the weapons at your disposal. So here’s the deal: you’re going to keep up your fire reserves, and in addition you’re going to drain this car battery every day before class.”

“But-”

“And before you object, let me make this clear, I’m not making a request. You’re going into combat training, that means you’re going to learn how to fight with both types of energy,” Coach George finished, cutting Vince off.

Vince took a deep breath and considered the situation. A car battery wasn’t all that much power in the grand scheme of things, but then again, with electricity a little went a long way. Still, it could be manageable, with the right precautions.

“I have to drain it every day before class. If I have any left over when gym is finished do I have to keep it with me?” Vince asked.

“I don’t care what you do after,” Coach George told him. “As long as you start my class each day with a full battery’s worth of power then you can discharge the rest down here when we’re done.”

Vince nodded. “I can work with that.”

“So glad to hear it,” Coach George said. “Now get out of here, kid, I’ve got work to do.”

Vince scrambled up and headed out the door. He made his way to the lifts, thankful he’d faced his problem today instead of waiting and worrying. It hadn’t been nearly as bad as he expected. He just had to start using another type of energy. In fighting. Which he would apparently be doing every day there was class.

As the lift began to rise Vince felt his stomach begin to drop.

\* \* \*

“Your move,” Mary said, setting her pawn down. Nick was rounding up people for putt-putt, Vince had gone to see Coach George about something, Alice was getting herself dolled up, and Hershel had gone to get lunch, leaving her the perfect opportunity for a match with Mr. Numbers.

“Indeed it is,” he said, quickly analyzing the board. “I find it interesting that you wish to continue these games, even after our disagreement of opinion over the mountain test.” He moved his knight.

“We have the same objective, we’re just going after it in different ways. I disagreed with your methods, not the results,” Mary said, positioning her rook.

“I see. And do you feel our tactic has borne fruit?”

“Everyone is a little bit closer after the experience, I’ll give you. Not to mention for the first time Alice got to see how her power can be useful, even lifesaving,” Mary said.

“Ah yes, is that why you claimed you had trouble lifting people with your gift?” Mr. Numbers asked.

Mary blinked in surprise. “That was true,” she told him.

“Then what about when you plucked the fit version of Mr. Daniels off the ground and held him restrained in mid-air while threatening him?” Mr. Number pointed out, shifting his knight once more.

“Roy is incredibly resistant to damage. That means I can hold him in the air indefinitely and not worry about crushing him. Other people aren’t quite as durable,” Mary replied.

It was Mr. Numbers’ turn to be surprised. He’d assumed she was lying in order to elevate Alice’s need and usefulness within the group. He had been wrong, though; she truly did possess that limitation. He mentally adjusted several calculations, then turned his focus back to the game.

“So the mountain was a success then,” he said.

“It bonded us, yes. It also made us the stronger of us realize our limitations, which is somewhat counterproductive to my work with Vince, Nick, and Alice,” Mary informed him, moving another pawn.

“Such endeavors must invariably suffer small setbacks on occasion,”

Mr. Numbers commented.

“Agreed, but let’s try to keep those to a minimum in the future. It will be better for everyone. Especially Mr. Transport,” Mary chuckled.

“What do you mean?”

“Ask him about when he went to pick up Hershel. I’ll let him explain the rest,” Mary said, a small grin still stuck to her face.

“I will,” Mr. Numbers agreed. He took the game in three more moves.



## 76.

The next day was a hectic one. Book bags were packed, breakfasts were scarfed, and new classes were attended. The time above ground passed more or less the same for everyone, getting the syllabi for their new courses and hurriedly finding the locations of their classrooms. There were lectures on attendance requirements and expectations for the year, but they may as well have been monologues about ham versus bacon on eggs benedict for all the HCP students could tell. Each one was focused on the coming afternoon and on the final hour of gym when they would at last begin a new regimen of training. Alternative and combat alike were excited, scared, and awash with the curiosity for something new. The morning flew by. However, there was still one roadblock before the new classes in gym could begin.

“Welcome back, everyone,” Dean Blaine greeted them as the freshmen wandered into his classroom. “I hope you all had an enjoyable vacation.” There was a grumbling of answer that seemed to lean slightly toward the affirmative. “Glad to hear it.”

As Nick took his usual seat near the middle row, he noticed something. The extraneous chairs appeared to be gone. He kept watch as the remaining ones filled up and confirmed his suspicions. There were exactly enough chairs for the current number of freshmen attending the class.

“Now, as I’m sure some of you have noticed, we’ve scaled back the clutter of extra seats over the break,” Dean Blaine said once everyone was seated.

“Took you long enough,” Stella called out.

“So pleasant to hear your voice again, Ms. Hawkins,” Dean Blaine said with his usual unwavering smile. “I assure we had our reasons for waiting, as well as for removing them over break. Would anyone care to take a stab at what those might have been?”

Alice’s hand shot up in the air as usual. Dean Blaine pointed at her out of habit, only doing so after realizing that her hand had, in fact, been up.

“You wanted us to look at the empty seats and be reminded that those were students like us who didn’t cut it. And to remind us that if we didn’t do our best our seat could be empty too.”

“Very good, Ms. Adair. So why did we remove them?”

“Because... because we’re starting a new semester, so you wanted the

empty chairs to be fresh examples?”

“Not quite, no. Anyone else?” Dean Blaine asked. This time a black-haired boy with a thin goatee raised his hand.

“Mr. Weaver,” Dean Blaine said, pointing at him.

“You’ve took the chairs away because you’re finished cutting people with that system,” he said.

“Correct, Mr. Weaver, all of which leads us into what I’d like to talk with you all about today. I think it’s time we discussed how the remainder of the Hero Certification Program will work as far as continuation and admittance,” Dean Blaine said.

“Admittance? We’re already in the program,” Stella pointed out.

“You’re in this year’s program, yes. I’m talking about the years to follow, though,” Dean Blaine told her. There was a ripple of stillness as the implications of his phrase settled in the minds of the class.

“Allow me to clarify before anyone asks further questions on the topic,” Dean Blaine said; years of giving this speech had left him well-prepared to avoid the tidal wave of panicked queries that would strike if he didn’t take charge. “Each year we take a small number of promising Supers and admit them to the freshman course of the program, the one you are all currently enrolled in. The first semester of that time is used to trim the fat in multiple ways, both by beginning the basic necessary physical conditioning and eliminating those who lack the qualities to move onward. The second semester is spent continuing to lay the groundwork for continuing in the program, giving you training a bit more specialized to your particular talents. Near the finale of the second semester, we hold another battle session to assess your combat abilities, as well as looking at your other skills through various tests to see how much you have grown, and how much further we think you can grow. At the end of this year you all have the option of applying for the next year’s program. I should caution you, however, there are only twenty-eight spots available.”

A few of the mentally swifter students reach the conclusion first, but it was of course Stella who voiced it.

“So three of us will be gone?”

“Correct,” Dean Blaine confirmed. “While you are, of course, welcome and encouraged to continue pursuing a degree at Lander, you will no longer be part of the Hero Certification Program. I should tell you that

generally speaking we have cut the class down to much fewer than thirty-one by now, so feel proud that you are part of such a talented group.”

Vince raised his hand hesitantly.

“I believe I said no questions, Mr. Reynolds; however, since I just took one from Ms. Hawkins, I will make one more exception for fairness before I expect that rule to be followed once again,” Dean Blaine said.

“Thank you, sir. I was just wondering, if it’s usually a lot lower than this, and there are twenty-eight spots, does that mean the sophomore year generally has unfilled spots?” Vince asked.

“An astute and fair question, and actually my next point,” Dean Blaine replied. “No, the classes are always filled and many are turned away. Let us say, hypothetically of course, that you don’t make the cut this year and are removed from the program, Mr. Reynolds. In the duration of next year you work hard and improve your abilities. When the year’s end comes around, you apply for the sophomore training once more. You are tested, measured, and found to be one of the twenty-eight most deserving candidates. You would then be accepted and placed into the next year’s course.”

“Wait, wait a second. You mean we’re not just competing with ourselves, we’re competing with everyone who ever completed their freshman year in the HCP and wants back in?” Stella asked.

“I’m going to choose to interpret that as a statement, rather than a question, since I feel I’ve been quite clear about my negative feelings towards those right now,” Dean Blaine said stonily. “That would be a correct summation of the situation, though. You should also note that the twenty-eight spot limitation is only for the sophomore year.”

The class relaxed a little bit. It was scary to have to jump through another hoop, but if it was only one time they each felt like they could make the cut.

“Junior year we only accept twenty students, and senior year it will be a paltry fifteen,” Dean Blaine continued. “Of course, the process will be the same each time, as will the existence of an outside pool of competition. And I suppose I should mention that of the fifteen accepted senior year, only ten will graduate and become fully licensed Heroes. You may now ask any additional questions you may have.”

“Why limit the number of Heroes out there?” Alex asked immediately.

“Because Heroes must be the best. They are tasked with dealing with

Supers, Powered, and all manner of natural disasters along with everyday problems. Just completing the course isn't enough; you have to prove you're better than everyone else. Because you'll have to be," Dean Blaine explained.

"What if there are more than ten capable Supers in the senior year class, one or two who would make awesome Heroes and are just below the cutoff point?" Gilbert tossed out.

"They are welcome to apply for the year once more and try again. Perhaps with another year of training they will rise in standing and make it out. If not, though, well, then they weren't the best, were they?" Dean Blaine queried back at him.

The class lapsed into a stunned silence, taking in everything that Dean Blaine had explained to them and trying to mentally assess their current standing.

"The ultimate thing to remember here is to work hard, try your best, and never forget that just getting by is not an option for students who want to be trusted with the lives of the weak and innocent," Dean Blaine advised them. "I know this system seems harsh, because it is. When Heroes fail, people die. That isn't a responsibility that can be trusted to just anyone. Keep that firmly in mind as you learn this semester, and I'm sure you'll find the gumption to push yourself just that little bit harder."

## 77.

“Rule number one is that you’re stronger than you think you are,” Coach Persephone said as she walked down the line of students before her. The two hours of conditioning were over and they had finally arrived at a more specialized training. She was handling her kids in the regular gym while George had taken his down a floor to a combat field. The faces staring back at her were uncertain and timid. She knew these expressions well: every year she was surrounded with the same looks on different faces. It was an arrangement of features that told the familiar story of someone who was powerful yet mortal, a Super who had to fear the mundane. She knew these expressions very well - she’d seen one in the mirror all her childhood, after all - and she took a particular joy in wiping them off any student in her charge.

“That isn’t just pretty talk, either. I’m not encouraging you, or trying to build your self-esteem. I’m being literal. Each of you is more powerful than you believe. Alice Adair, for example, can fly. Now, how useful would you rate that skill in combat, Mr. Weaver?”

“Not very,” said Rich, body language solid but voice hesitant.

“You’d be right much of the time,” Coach Persephone agreed. “In circumstances where battle is taking place in an elevated location, or the enemy has the high ground, or even mid-air, though, you would be very incorrect. The ability to move freely through the air is a very rare talent among Supers, and one that has turned the tide of many battles. What about Tiffani Hunt’s ability to create illusions? Any thoughts on its battle worthiness, Mr. Murray?”

“Well,” Will began thoughtfully. “Normally no, it wouldn’t be useful in a one-on-one battle in an open plain. If it were used to alter the opponent’s perception of the environment, though, it could be downright deadly if used properly.”

“Mr. Weaver has hit upon the magic phrase,” Coach Persephone praised. “And that is ‘if used properly.’ You see, none of you are a tremendous threat in a regular fistfight, but we don’t deal with those situations. We deal with criminals and villains that are clever as well as powerful. Being a Hero very rarely boils down to something as simple as a fistfight. So while you are under my care it is important that you understand the purpose of this course. I’m not trying to teach you how to fight like the students in the combat course. I’m teaching you how to find the right scenarios where you are deadly, and then how to orchestrate them in a field of battle.”

She paused for a moment, seeming to collect her thoughts. In reality she had given this speech many times and found a small break here drove home her next words well.

“To put it more concisely, Coach George is turning your fellow classmates into tanks. But as for me, I’m building snipers.”

\* \* \*

“Rule number one is that you’re weaker than you think you are,” Coach George said, pacing the line with a half snarl plastered to his face. He knew all too well the faces that stood before him in the sparse concrete combat area under the glaring fluorescent lights; they were the same cocky stares that met him every year at this time. These were the kids who grew up unstoppable. They didn’t understand fear or insecurity. Sure, some of them knew what the words meant, but they didn’t *know* the horror of wondering if you’ll be able to walk out of a bad situation alive. They weren’t picked on or made to eat dirt, though plenty of them had done the picking. These were the expressions of arrogant idiots who’d never known what it was to really lose - George had worn one himself for longer than he cared to admit - and he took a special joy in smashing it off the face of any student in his care.

“I know you all grew up powerful, the baddest-ass kid on the block,” Coach George continued. “I’ll bet, with the exception of you who had Supers for teachers, none of you has even lost a fight before Lander. Hope you enjoyed it, kids, because that ride of luxury stopped the minute you stepped into my gym. This course is designed to show you just how weak you all really are, so that I can teach you how to be strong. Reynolds, punch Castillo in the mouth.”

“What?” Vince asked, making no move to strike Thomas, who was standing next to him. “Why would I do that?”

“Wrong answer, Reynolds. Fifty push-ups. Now,” Coach George ordered.

Vince looked at him uncertainly, then got down to the floor and began his penance.

“You see, this is not playtime. I’m going to be teaching you how to fight with the intent of taking an opponent down for the count. Me giving an order should be met with instant obedience, because there will be times when that order will save the life of you or another. Foster, punch Griffen in the mouth.”

Alex never even had a chance to react before Sasha’s fist buried itself

in his unsuspecting jaw. The impact knocked him to the ground.

“Good job, Foster. The sound of flesh on flesh impact was the only acceptable answer there. Griffen, fifty push-ups,” Coach George said.

“But you told her to hit me!” Alex pointed out from his prone position as he rubbed his jaw.

“And if I told you not to dodge then you’d get a ‘good job’, too. But you didn’t duck a fist flying at your face. That shit doesn’t float in combat training,” Coach George explained.

Alex groaned, but he flipped over and began doing his own push-ups.

“Now, I’m sure at this moment Persephone is giving her kids a pep talk about how to use their special talents to be better Heroes. You lot don’t have special talents, though, you only have the one: kicking ass. Sure, it comes in different flavors, but at the end of the day that’s what it all boils down to. I’m going to tear you down and then build you up again, but this time the right way,” Coach George declared.

The gym was silent save for the soft grunts of Vince and Alex still doing their push-up. That was fine; George didn’t have to hear the grumbles and the ‘yeah, rights’ to know they were there. Kids like these didn’t take anyone’s authority on words.

“I know each of you is thinking that this speech doesn’t apply to you. That you’re the exception to the rule, a true warrior in every way, and that I don’t know a damn thing about combat. I know because I’ve been you, and I’m going to do with you what my coach did to us. I’m going to establish right here and now who the authority on the subject of winning fights is.”

Coach George shrugged off the jacket of his uniform and cracked his knuckles for show. “Anyone who wants to see where they stack against the old timer can step up now. One by one I’ll be glad to knock you down.”

Smarter students of this age, ones who had been on the losing end of a few fights, might have suspected that Coach George wouldn’t make an offer like this unless he was able to follow through on it. Unfortunately for a large portion of the class, they didn’t fall into that demographic, and as such hadn’t learned just how humiliating and devastating a loss can be.

Yet.

## 78.

"This is some kind of trick, right?" Roy asked as the rest of the students stared uncertainly at Coach George.

"Not at all, Daniels. This is part of the learning experience," Coach George said.

"What exactly are we supposed to learn?" Sasha ventured to ask.

"Respect. Not the kind that makes you say 'sir' and 'ma'am', the kind that lets you trust implicitly that I know what I'm doing. This class will be far more lucrative for you all if you do as I tell you, when I tell you."

"Of course we will, you're our teacher," Jill assured him.

"Some of you will," Coach George agreed. "Some of you need to really know you should, though. Need to know it in a visceral way, a way that can only come by having the man you're learning from best you in a fight. I'm not condemning that fact, I'm acknowledging it for what it is and getting it addressed right here and now. Nobody has to fight me, and there won't be punishment for anyone who does. Just ask yourself this simple question: can you one hundred percent trust the battle instructions of a teacher you haven't tested firsthand? If so, then fine; if not, then let's fix that problem."

There was a brief silence after Coach George finished, broken almost immediately by Roy's deep, confident voice.

"Oh I have so got dibs on first."

\* \* \*

"The first step is understanding exactly what it is your power does," Coach Persephone instructed her students. "This is also the last step, because it is a step that never truly becomes accomplished. Trying to define the miraculous is a capital enterprise in futility. Still, we can improve our understanding, and from there we gain strength."

Nick leaned over and whispered to Alice, "If I cough the words 'hippie bullshit' you think anyone will notice?"

"Shush!" Alice snapped at him.

"Nick Campbell," Coach Persephone said without turning to face him. "Do you have a problem with my instructions?"



“Yeah, look, not to stir the pot or anything, but what about people like me? I mean, hell, I don’t even know how my power works really, let alone have a clue on how to understand it,” Nick told her, stepping forward from the line.

“You manipulate probability,” Coach Persephone said.

“Probabilily,” Nick said, grinning slightly.

“That is somewhat abstract, I’ll give you. If you want my honest advice, though, and not just an opportunity to show the class how you can make a bad joke from a common word, I would tell you experimentation is the key,” Coach Persephone said. “Start trying to do things with your power you haven’t done before. As you find things that work and things that don’t, you will grow closer to understanding the mechanics behind your ability.”

“Ah, great idea. Thanks, teach,” Nick said, retaking his place beside Alice.

“Nick Campbell, walk over here right now,” Coach Persephone told him.

“What’d I do? I asked a question,” Nick began protesting.

“Just walk over here, young man,” she reiterated.

Nick let out an exaggerated sigh and began slowly schlepping toward his teacher. It wasn’t far, maybe thirty feet at the max, and yet he only made it halfway. Once there, Nick proceeded to jerk his head back, twitch slightly, and collapse onto the ground.

\* \* \*

“Anyone else?” Coach George asked. Scattered around him were the bruised and often unconscious figures of several freshmen students, Roy, Stella, Michael, and Sasha among them. The ground in the area was now cracked, and in several places there were scorch marks burned into the surface. Most changed of all in the scenery, though, was Coach George himself. Coach George was a shifter it seemed, one of the more common types of Supers, especially of those who specialized in combat. Coach George was a bit extra special, though, for while shifters like Hershel turned into Roy, or the sophomore Ben had turned into a lizardman, Coach George turned into something different.

“So is he technically a robot or a cyborg?” Vince asked Jill, one of the evidently more intelligent students who had opted to decline Coach George’s

challenge.

“You’d probably have to ask my brother on that one. I can’t really connect with him the way I do other machines, though, so my money is for cyborg,” Jill replied.

Coach George had shifted into a man of metal, but unlike Stella, he was a more functional model. His eyes seemed to act as scanners, and several times he had blasted a charging student with a weapon from his body. His favorites seemed to be the energy guns that came out of his forearms.

“It looks we’re done here then,” Coach George told them, turning back into his human form. His pants and shirt were ripped and singed in a few places, but the skin he showed had no injury of any kind.

“When we’re done, someone go grab the healer girl to clean up in here, but first I want to say something. Pay attention, those of you on the floor who can still hear. Today was an important lesson: it taught you what failure is, some of you for the first time. For others it was one you’ve had before but could stand a little repeating. I meant what I said, though: I don’t hold it against you that you needed to test my mettle. I did the same thing to my coach when I was in your spot, and my ass wound up on that same floor. So listen close, kiddos, because this is the part that matters. Today I taught you how to lose, so that starting Monday I can teach you how to win. Come ready to hurt and ready to learn. Class dismissed.”

“Well, that was pretty horrifying to watch,” Thomas said, walking over to Vince and Alex.

“Agreed,” Alex said. “I say we hit the showers, go get dinner, and try very hard to forget what we’re coming back to on Monday.”

“I’ll catch up with you guys,” Vince said. “Somebody still needs to go get Camille.”

“I can do that, we’re somewhat friends after all,” Thomas volunteered.

Vince waved him off. “Don’t worry about it. I still owe her a thanks from Halloween anyway.”

“Very well,” Thomas said. “At least she should be free. It’s not like anyone in the alternative training class will need healing.”

\* \* \*

“If you’re wondering why you can’t move, it’s because I’ve scrambled the receptors to your nervous system,” Coach Persephone explained to Nick’s

twitching, collapsed form. “I’m not targeting any of the automated parts like heart and breathing, so you’ll be fine when I stop. Although, you might be a bit twitchy for a few hours.”

“How are you doing that?” Tiffani Hunt asked from the line.

“As a child, I always seemed to be able to turn people’s moods with ease. Eventually it was diagnosed that I was a Super, though at the time we all believed I had a minor ability to influence people’s minds. In an effort to understand my power, I did exactly what I told Nick here to do: I experimented with new things I’d never tried to before. Most failed, but some didn’t, and eventually I made a fascinating discovery,” Coach Persephone said, walking the rest of the way over to Nick and staring down at him.

“I learned I didn’t have power over the mind, I had the ability to, at will, create, emit, and direct pheromones of all types. At first I was disappointed, thinking the mind power to be more useful. My time at Lander taught me otherwise, though. I learned there are all sorts of things that pheromones influence and control. Did you know there are even some that can disrupt the nervous system?”

Nick made a slight gurgling sound from his place on the floor.

“Your homework over the weekend is to try one new way to use your power. Failure or success is irrelevant, I only demand that you try. Dismissed,” Coach Persephone told them. With that she turned and began heading back toward the exit.

Camille began moving toward Nick’s pitiful form to administer some help, but the sound of her name being called in a familiar voice pulled her attention away rapidly.

“Hey, Camille!” Vince yelled, jogging over from the entrance to the gym.

Camille took very deep, very rapid, very unsuccessful steadying breaths. She’d known this was going to happen eventually. It was unavoidable: he was just the kind of guy who had to thank anyone who’d given him aid.

“Coach George sent me up here,” Vince explained once he reached her. “He did kind of a number of our combat class and a lot of the guys could use some healing. Do you mind?”

Camille shook her head no and began to hurry past him toward where she was needed, but he stepped in front of her before she made it.

“One more thing. I just wanted to say thank you for helping me on Halloween. You guys really pulled me out of a tight spot there, and I don’t know what I would have done without you. So thank you, a lot.”

“No problem,” Camille squeaked, flushing bright red and bustling past him toward the door. To her credit she didn’t break into a full on sprint until she was out of the gym and on her way to the lower floor. Her heart was racing and her breathing was more erratic than a drunken bull runner’s, but she slowly got both back under control. It looked like he didn’t remember, and she wasn’t sure how she felt about that. It made things easier, though, and that was something.

Upstairs, Vince was quite uncertain how, but he had a strange feeling he’d offended the girl he meant to thank. Added onto the tingle in his brain that there was something familiar about her, Vince had no idea what to make of the small female. Instead he wandered over to the circle of fellow students watching with amusement as Nick slowly regained control of his limbs.

## 79.

“How you feeling, buddy?” Vince asked, handing Nick a glass of water. They were back in Melbrook, lounging the common room with Alice, Mary, and Hershel. It had taken Nick twenty minutes before he could effectively coordinate his movements, and even then he’d needed help making it to the dorm.

“Glitchy,” Nick replied, sipping the water carefully. “That woman is a nutjob. Who just attacks a student on the first day?”

“Coach George attacked around eight, but they sort of volunteered for it,” Hershel commented. Roy had shifted back not long after being healed, happy to fade away after another trouncing. He wasn’t used to losing, especially not this often.

“Volunteered is the key word there. I just asked a simple question,” Nick said.

“You were being an asinine smartass, no surprise,” Alice corrected. “Just be glad I don’t have her power.”

“At this particular moment I’m more wishing no one had her power,” Nick replied. “Let’s just grab some dinner, rent some movies, and spend the rest of the night relaxing.”

“Actually, if you guys are interested, I was sort of planning to go out tonight,” Hershel said tentatively.

“Well, yeah, we assumed Roy would be on the prowl,” Vince said.

“No. I mean me. Hershel. I want to go to a club tonight.”

There was a soft creak of bones as everyone shifted their bodies to gaze at the chair where Hershel was lounging.

“But you don’t go out,” Vince ventured.

“I don’t, because Roy does and it keeps things much more amiable between us if I give him the weekends. Tonight, though, he isn’t feeling like his usual partying self due to Coach George’s smack down. So I thought it was a good opportunity to make use of a Friday while I have one,” Hershel explained. “Like I said at the party, I don’t want all of my college experiences to be secondhand.”

“I’m in,” Nick nearly shouted.

“You just had your nervous system rewired an hour ago,” Mary told him.

“And I’m feeling much better,” Nick said. “Hershel on the dance floor, though? No way in hell am I missing this.”

“Guess that means I’m in, too,” Vince said.

“You want to see Hershel bust a move too?” Alice asked.

“No, I just don’t trust Nick not to try and set him up in some sort of elaborate and embarrassing situation,” Vince said.

“Good call,” Nick agreed.

“I’ll be fine,” Hershel told him. “I would love it if you guys came, though. Alex is already in, and I figured we could invite everyone else as well.”

“I’m certainly not going to stay home by myself,” Alice said, a small chime of happiness echoing through her at being able to truthfully make such a statement.

“I’ll call Sasha and Will,” Vince volunteered.

“What about you, Mary?” Hershel tried to ask nonchalantly.

Mary waited a moment, savoring the uncertainty as only a girl being courted for the first time is able to do, then let out her answer in a small, reserved voice.

“I think that sounds like fun.”

“Awesome,” Hershel said, a wide grin breaking through his face’s futile restraint attempts.

\* \* \*

“No. No. No. No. Dear lord in heaven, no. No. No. Maybe. No.” Alice paused to take a breath and move to another area of Mary’s closet. Mary had, much to her almost immediate regret, asked for Alice’s input on what to wear out to the club. What she had expected would be a two-minute process to confirm an outfit had turned into an endless critique of Mary’s entire wardrobe.

“I thought the yellow shirt looked nice,” Mary ventured.

“Nice is for church, class, and dinner with the family,” Alice told her.

“Going out to the club is about grabbing attention and keeping it there.”

“That’s not really how I like to dress,” Mary told her, not quite able to stop herself from glancing down at her small frame.

Alice stared at her a minute, then realization of what Mary meant clicked into place.

“Oh no no no, I don’t mean slutty. That’s for costume parties and the like. I just mean attention-grabbing. The right combinations of colors and cuts to draw the eye, highlighting your own look just enough to make sure their gazes stay on you. In that case, less is more. Just trust me, Mary, when it comes to fashion I’ve been a Super for years.”

“You do always dress nicely,” Mary acquiesced.

“Thank you,” Alice said, turning her attention back to the closet. “Your clothes aren’t bad either. They’re just a little... eclectic.”

“When you’re in the woods, function tends to trump fashion relentlessly,” Mary said.

“I wouldn’t know. The closest we ever really came to roughing it in my family was staying at a hotel that had an indoor garden,” Alice said.

“You should go sometime. The air, the smells, the quiet: it’s a wholly unique experience,” Mary told Alice, her eyes drifting off as she remembered her peaceful trailer in the forest.

“I might just do that over the summer,” Alice said. “Now that I can, it’d be nice to try.”

“Now that you can?”

“Yeah. Now... post-procedure. I had to limit my time outdoors before,” Alice said.

“Oh, because of the floating,” Mary surmised.

“Bingo. When I was really happy, I floated. If there wasn’t a ceiling to stop me that meant a much longer fall to the ground. Being outside was basically taking my life in my hands,” Alice explained.

“That seems awful,” Mary said. “So every time you had a rush of joy it was soon followed by a plummet to the ground? How did you deal with that?”

“Mostly I stopped doing things that made me too happy,” Alice

replied. "It wasn't hard in my house. The goal was just to maintain a constant neutral, never have any strong emotions burst through."

"You weren't very good at it," Mary said.

Alice jerked her head up sharply and met Mary's eyes. Mary shook her head. "I wasn't listening. I've just gotten to know you. You took to Lander so easily, accepted this new way of life with almost no problem besides hesitance and fear. Despite how hard you worked to be guarded throughout your life, you even made friends with a telepath. There's no way a girl like that was good at locking down her feelings all the time."

Alice said nothing at first, then placed a shirt on the bed.

"Let's try the purple top with the jeans I picked out earlier," Alice said.

"Sounds good," Mary agreed.

"If the look works then we can finally get to the real fun."

"Real fun?" Mary asked.

"Oh yeah," Alice confirmed with a gleeful glint in her eye. "Shoes."



## 80.

To say the music was loud would be an understatement of criminal magnitudes. The music here wasn't so much heard as it was felt, the bass quaking through one's bones and forcefully shaking one's brain. It was easily louder than the country western club they had gone to last semester; however, this one had evidently possessed a designer with a modicum of sense. The club was split up into several different rooms. There was a patio outside, several rooms for lounging, and one wherein dancing was expected. The dance room was where the music reached its tooth-chattering apex, but the others were habitable enough to allow some conversation.

It was in one of the lounging rooms that the Lander students settled down to relax. The final tally had wound up being all of the Melbrook students along with Jill, Will, and Alex. Sasha had been too sore from the day's class and they'd had no luck reaching Thomas. They were still a sizable crowd, and as such grabbed hold of a large circular booth where they could all sit comfortably.

"So, not to sound like the clubbing newbie here, but now what do we do?" Mary asked after they'd been relaxing in their booth for half an hour.

"Well, normally by this point Roy would be drinking heavily, dancing on the floor, and trying to figure out which girl to bring home. I think that's pretty much the norm for club activities," Hershel said. "Right?"

"Let's hope not," Vince said. "We've all got marked hands and are underage so drinking is out. Will and I are in relationships so we can't chase girls with you, and all that leaves for us is dancing."

"Maybe later on that one," Hershel said. He very much wanted to ask Mary, who was currently sipping cranberry juice through a straw on the other side of the booth, if she would care to dance. Wanting to and having the courage to were proving to be very different things, though. So instead he was pushing it off, convincing himself it would somehow grow easier as the night progressed.

"Hey, let's not give up on bringing girls home yet," Nick butted in. "Alex and I aren't taken. We can roam the club for young, impressionable women."

"I'm going to leave an impression in your skull," Alice threatened. "Regardless, if we keep sitting here all we'll do is keep sitting here. Mary, Jill, come with me. We're going to put ourselves near the dance floor and see

how many boys come calling.”

“Finally, let’s move,” Jill said.

“Actually I’m comfortable right here-” Mary tried to object, but Alice took her by the shoulders and began marching her into the next room.

“Read my mind already,” Alice urged her. Mary had actually been tuning out thoughts tonight, the ambient sound of music uncomfortably reminding her of the days when she couldn’t make the voices stop. Still, she reached into Alice’s mind and listened. It seemed Alice was getting the girls away from the booth in order to force Hershel into making a move. Alice felt that if they stayed he would dither all night and lose the opportunity, but if he was scared other boys were dancing with Mary, it might push him to action.

By the time Mary had processed it all they were in the crisp chill of the outdoor area and safely out of earshot from the table. Granted, even in the lounge room ten feet would put you easily out of earshot from someone.

“I think he would have asked me,” Mary said, stopping the progression toward the dance room.

“He thinks so, too, and he would have kept thinking that until we had to leave and it wasn’t done,” Alice countered.

“Actually, I’m with Alice here,” Jill chimed in. “Boys are cowards and morons for the most part. I love my brother, but do you know how he got that girlfriend of his?”

“How?” Mary asked.

“She asked him out. Twice, because the first time he didn’t get that it was a date. You have to give them little pushes here and there or you’ll be waiting forever for them to make a freaking move,” Jill told her.

“This is a little push?”

“You’re not making out with some dude in the bathroom, you’re going with the other single girls to see if anyone will ask you to dance. This is pretty much as gently as we can remind him that other guys find you attractive, too,” Alice assured her.

“I guess it can’t hurt to go watch the people dancing,” Mary caved.

“Atta girl; we’ll have him eating out of your hand in no time.”

\* \* \*

“Is it me, or did this just turn into a total sausage fest?” Nick asked as the girls scampered away.

“No, you’re dead on,” Alex agreed.

“That seemed... odd,” Hershel said. “They just sort of all bolted away.”

“Alice took Mary away to make you chase after her,” Will said simply. “They want you to go ask her to dance before some other guy beats you to it.”

“How do you know that?” Vince asked.

“Could be a lot of things. Could be that I have a much higher IQ than you guys. Could be because I grew up with a twin sister and have a slight insight into how girls think. Could be the bug I slipped onto Jill before we came out tonight,” Will said, pointing to his ear. Closer inspection would reveal a small device nestled in one of its cartilage curves.

“You’re kidding,” Nick declared.

“Not at all,” Will said. “My sister has a tendency toward telling very large, very gay men how sexy I think they are when we are out at clubs. She finds it endlessly hilarious, thus I’ve begun taking precautions so I can at least be forewarned when she hatches such a scheme.”

“Yeesh. Glad I’m an only child,” Nick said.

“Wait, so they did that specifically so I would ask Mary to dance? And Mary went along with it, so that means she wants me to ask, right?” Hershel said uncertainly.

“I have no problem betraying my sister’s confidence. Mary’s is another matter. If you want to find out whether she wants to dance with you or not, then I suggest you ask her,” Will told him.

“Why don’t we all go in there?” Vince said. “That way Hershel doesn’t seem like he was following them, it’s on all of us.”

“Works for me,” Nick said.

“I’ll stay here and hold the booth,” Will volunteered.

Vince waved him off. “There are plenty of booths, we can get another. You should come with us.”

“Normally I would agree; however, it seems Jill just located a bodybuilder in that room and is describing her very flexible, very

experimental brother,” Will explained.

“Oh. Well then... see you in a few,” Vince said.

“I’ll be here,” Will cheerfully replied.

## 81.

“Why, hello there, you foxy ladies.”

“Get lost, dirt bag,” Alice snapped at the poor male uttering such a trite line.

“Dirt bag? Really? I think I have more fastidious hygiene than even you, Princess,” Nick shot back, having been the poor line-delivering male in question.

“You drop a sleazy opener, you gotta be prepared for the consequences,” Alice said with a shrug. “What brings you boys out here?”

Nick had approached Alice and Mary with Hershel, Vince, and Alex just a few steps behind. The girls were standing by a large door that opened into the dance room. There were ample people huddling in the same area since it provided an excellent balance. It was outdoors, but the body heat from the physical activity rolled out, creating a pleasant temperature. Plus it allowed one to see the gyrating and be approached while still far enough from the eardrum-shattering music to hold a conversation.

“I thought I might grace one of these lucky gals with the pleasure of my company on the dance floor,” Nick said.

“And I thought we might be needed to tend to the wounds after he gets slapped silly,” Vince joined in.

“One time, one time I got slapped at Halloween and you punks won’t let it go,” Nick said.

“She slapped you with a Bible, man. That’s the sort of thing that sticks in people’s minds,” Alex reminded him.

“Fascinating as you boys are, could you proceed with Nick’s slapfest elsewhere? No men are going to want to approach us if we’re already surrounded by other guys,” Alice said, proving just how little she knew about real world courting and the opposite sex.

“I don’t mind if they hang out,” Mary countered.

“Maybe not, but that hunky guy in the tank top who’s been eyeing you will. Priorities, sweetheart, seriously,” Alice said, taking Mary’s hand and dragging her away from the boys.

“There is no hunky guy in a tank top, is there?” Mary asked as she

was pulled.

“Oh no, there is. He’s just making eyes at a trampy blonde in the corner,” Alice explained.

Mary glanced over and noticed the girl.

“She’s dressed like everyone else. What exactly makes her trampy?”

“The fact that the hot guy is looking at her instead of us.”

\* \* \*

“And again we have sausage fest,” Nick said with a sigh.

“It’s easy to correct, though; let’s go hit the dance floor and grab us some hotties,” Alex pointed out.

“Not a bad idea-”

“Hey guys! Vince! Alex!” The boys turned their heads to find Thomas jogging over to them from the entrance.

“Hey, what’s going on? Did you get my message?” Vince asked.

“I didn’t know you left one, so no,” Thomas said, shaking his head. “Stella took my and her other friends’ phones after gym. She said we were all going out tonight to have some fun or she’d crush them.”

“That’s certainly... aggressive,” Hershel said after some hasty vocabulary scrambling.

“That’s Stella, she doesn’t take no for an answer. It was well-intentioned, though. If she hadn’t done it we’d have all stayed in and licked our wounds instead of going out,” Thomas said, a slight defensiveness in his voice.

“You keep referencing ‘we’ but you’re the only one here,” Nick said.

“Oh yeah, the girls went to go check their purses at the front counter,” Thomas explained.

“Thank the lord, you brought more women,” Nick said.

“I did, and actually I think they’re coming out now if my vision serves me well.”

Sure enough, Stella’s trademark blonde braids appeared around the same corner Thomas had come from, Violet following close behind, and

Camille looking around nervously at the end of the line. They spotted Thomas and the others and began making their way over, with the exception of Camille, who suddenly went stock still and had an intense inner debate before finally following suit.

\* \* \*

“Don’t I know you?”

“Aren’t guys the ones who are supposed to use that line?” Alice replied.

“No, I’m serious,” said the speaker, a brunette who had been walking past them. She had shoulder-length hair and an infectious smile. “We had poli-sci together last semester. You were the chick with her hand always in the air.”

Alice studied the girl for a moment. She did indeed look familiar, and now that Alice was thinking, there had been a similarly cheery voice echoing through the class from time to time.

“I think you’re right,” Alice admitted. “I’m Alice.”

“I’m Natalie,” Natalie said. “But everyone calls me Bubbles. So, how’ve you been?”

“Um, good, I guess,” Alice said. “You know, passed the class, now on to new ones. You?”

“I’m doing awesome! I managed to squeak by that one and my math class, and I only barely failed Shakespearean literature, so it’s way fewer classes than I thought I’d have to be retaking. Aside from that, I went skiing with my family over break and that was sooooo much fun. Then there was Christmas and I mean, seriously, who doesn’t love Christmas? Plus I’m out tonight with my new roommate and his best friend and just having a crazy good time. The guys are so cute out here, right? So who’s your friend?”

“I’m Mary, and I think I can see why they call you Bubbles. You certainly have a cheerful attitude.”

“Aw, that is so nice, thank you,” Bubbles said. “Yeah, that’s what everyone thinks at first, but no, that’s not why they call me Bubbles. I got my nickname cause I have the cutest ability ever. I can make bubbles appear all over the place. It makes for some awesome foam parties like you wouldn’t believe. I mean, last year my friend Jenny and I went to this kegger and-”

“Wait, I’m sorry to cut you off, but I need clarification,” Alice said.

“What do you mean you can make bubbles appear?”

“I can make them appear,” Bubbles replied. She raised open her hand and sure enough, bubbles began glistening into existence a few inches above it. “I can do all sorts of sizes and numbers of them, too. I’m really good at it.”

“So you’re... a Super?” Alice said, more out of disbelief than as a genuine question.

“Yup! You should meet my roommate. His ability is even cooler. He’s a Powered, though, so he can’t really do it on demand, but it’s still super neat. Come on, I’ll introduce you!” Bubbles declared, virtually bouncing off toward a lounge room.

“I don’t think it’s the best idea for us to be seen with Supers who are out in the open with their abilities,” Mary whispered.

“No, it is definitely a bad idea. But I didn’t know there were any Supers here outside of the HCP. And to be honest, I never met another Powered. Cheery McChatter isn’t my first choice for a hanging out companion either, but I’m not sure I can walk away from this without seeing at least a little bit more. Can you?” Alice whispered back.

Mary couldn’t.



## 82.

Camille couldn't believe she'd let herself wind up in this situation. She should have just let Stella crush the phone instead of strong-arming her out tonight. It wasn't just Stella and Violet forcing her that had convinced her to leave the dorm, though; it was a desire to get away from the events of the day. She didn't want to sit at home and brood all night so she thought going out with her friends, even to a place she had zero desire to be, would at least get her mind off the encounter with Vince.

Seeing as Vince was now standing only a few feet away from her, that plan had failed about as horrifically as was conceivably possible. The others were talking and figuring out where to go next, but Camille was just trying to maintain and hold it together. Every now and then she would catch Vince's eyes darting over to her. She reassured herself it was okay each time. He didn't remember her. She might look familiar, but there was no way he would place her. It had probably just been another day for him, and it was all so long-

"Hey!" Vince said, snapping his fingers and looking at Camille. "I just remembered where I know you from."

Camille let out a very soft, very high-pitched squeak and turned bright red.

\* \* \*

"Freak!"

"Weirdo!"

"Monster!"

"Leave me alone," Camille cried softly, curled up in a ball on the concrete. She'd just wanted to walk down to the pool, the day was so hot. She should have known better. Of course the other kids would be out with the same idea. Of course they would see her. She felt so stupid as she lay there, waiting for them to tire of throwing sticks and insults at her. She hoped it wouldn't be much longer; usually by now an adult would have come by.

"My daddy says Supers are a menace," Billy yelled at her, hurling a good-sized branch. Thankfully his small arms hadn't yet learned to aim well.

"They're Heroes," Camille yelled back. She shouldn't have done that, she regretted it the minute she did. She should have just laid there and been

quiet while they assaulted her. Now it would be worse.

“Nuh uh,” Rick said, dropping his own stick and walking over to her. Billy might be the leader, but Rick was the enforcer, always willing to walk the extra mile of pain where others would shy off. “Only a few of them are Heroes, and they don’t fix everything the others mess up.”

“I’m sorry,” Camille sobbed.

“You’re a freak,” Rick said kicking her once in the back. This was new; they’d never gotten close to hurt her before. It was tentative: Rick was testing the waters. He kicked her once more. A whole new world of possibilities was opening up before his cruel little eyes. It seemed girls weren’t immune to being hit the way everybody tried to teach him. There was no magical force stopping him from kicking the freak just like she was a boy. He did it again just to reinforce the point. She let a cry slip past her lips when he did it this time. A smile began to form on his face. It lingered there for only a moment before a set of knuckles crashed into it, fracturing his jaw and knocking out several teeth in the process.

“Whhhoduhhelllls,” Rick gurgled from his bloody mouth, trying to pull himself up from the ground. Camille opened her eyes as well, curiosity at the sudden silence that had fallen over her tormentors. Both the downed torturer and the saved victim looked up and saw the boy who had saved her. It was an image that would stay with both of them for the rest of their lives.

He was long and lean, with clothes that looked like they hadn’t been washed in weeks, if ever. There was some dirt on his hands and face, his skin tan from all the time spent outdoors. His eyes were a gleaming blue and his hair was curiously colored a metallic silver.

“You don’t hit girls,” the boy said simply. He extended a hand to Camille, who gladly took it and was pulled to her feet.

“Hey, you can’t just punch our friend,” Billy said. The others had been momentarily struck dumb when this strange kid had run across the street of their small suburb and coldcocked Rick, but they were coming round to their senses. One such sense was the ability to realize it was still five of them against one of him.

“He was kicking a girl,” the boy replied.

“Well, now we’re going to beat up both of you,” Billy said, motioning for the others to begin closing in.

The boy looked at the other children, then at Billy, then his blue eyes

stared at Camille for several seconds. He turned back to Billy and shook his head.

“No.”

“What do you mean, no?” Billy asked, confused.

“I mean I can’t let you beat us up. I won’t let you hurt her,” the boy replied with that same unwavering tone. There was no fear, no uncertainty, just a calm denial of what was about to happen.

“You think you can take us all?”

“Yes.”

Billy glanced at the others. They were growing restless. This kid wasn’t responding the way others did when confronted with a large group. They were beginning to wonder if something was different here. If he wanted to maintain control, Billy had to act now.

“Fine. Forget the freak, get him!” Billy yelled, charging at the boy. The others hesitated only a moment before doing the same. Billy ran head on, expecting to sink his shoulder into the boy’s gut and drive him to the ground. Instead he felt a fist bury itself in his ear, destroying his sense of balance and sending him sprawling. By the time he was able to right himself and look up it was already over. There were bloody noses and faces on his companions, who were scattered around the ground, but the boy was still standing in the same spot, looking unharmed.

“You don’t hit girls,” the boy said one last time. “Or people like me will stop you.” He turned to Camille. “I’ll walk you home.”

“Thank you,” she said, tears still falling down her face, though she wasn’t quite sure why anymore.

The two walked in silence for the first block or so, the boy naturally silent and Camille uncertain of what to say. Finally she decided to begin with the basics.

“What’s your name?” she asked the boy.

“Vince,” he replied. “Yours?”

“Camy Belden,” she said, preferring the nickname her parents had given her to the stuffy one she’d been born with. “It’s nice to meet you, Vince... what’s your last name?”

“I don’t have one,” he replied. “My dad says he threw his away, so he

doesn't have one to pass onto me. He also says if I grow into a good man he'll help me find one, though."

"Oh. That's... cool," Camille said, not sure of what to make of such a thing. "How old are you?"

"Nine. You?"

"I'm nine, too," she said, smiling inwardly. He was the same age as she was. That made her inexplicably happy.

"Neat," Vince said. "You seem pretty nice. I'm sorry those guys were being so mean to you."

Camille shook her head. "It's not about me being nice. They don't like me because I'm a Super. They say it makes me freak."

"You're a Super?" Vince yelled, his voice full of shock.

"Um, yes," Camille said, kicking herself once more for opening her big mouth. He probably hated them too, and now he would hate her and be sad he'd even bothered saving her. Why did she say anything?

"That's awesome!" Vince said excitedly. "What's your ability? Is it cool? How long have you known?"

Camille didn't quite know how to respond to this. Everyone said being a Super was great, yet everyone she met seemed to treat her badly because of it. Camille was too young to understand something as complex as that level of jealousy, but she could still feel the hatred from it. Vince wasn't acting that way, though. He really seemed to like it.

"I take away scrapes and bruises by touching someone," Camille explained. "But then I can also give those scrapes and bruises to other people if I touch them."

"Oh wow, so you're sort of an absorber then."

"Absorber?"

"It means you kind of take something into yourself, hold it there, then release it when you want to. It's what my father says I am," Vince explained.

"You're a Super, too?" Camille asked.

"No." Vince's face fell immediately and his pace slowed down a touch. "I'm just a Powered. I can't really control my ability at all. I just make batteries go dead or kill the campfire by accident. When it comes out it's

worse, though. I've set things on fire by accident three times just this year."

"I'm sorry," Camille said.

"It's okay," Vince said, shrugging off the dour mood. "I just have to help people in different ways, like by learning how to fight."

"You sure did that," Camille said, remembering how he'd so easily knocked down the children that had seemed unstoppable to her for so long.

"I still have a long way to go," Vince said. "Besides, I don't like fighting very much. I already hurt people enough by accident with my power. You're lucky you get to make them feel better."

"I don't feel lucky," Camille admitted for the first time. She'd never met anyone else with powers before, never had anyone to talk about this sort of thing with. "I feel like nobody likes me, like I'm always getting picked on just because I can do something they can't. I don't even want to do it; I just want to be normal." Tears once again found their way down her small cheeks.

"You're not using it, maybe that's why you hate it so much," Vince told her.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean you're special. You can do something others can't, no matter how hard they work at it. You won't ever be normal. You can be a Super, though. You can use your ability to help people and make a difference."

"But they'll still hate me," Camille said,

"Maybe. Maybe not. Either way, won't you be happier as the one saving people than the one needing saving?"

"I don't know," Camille admitted.

"Might be worth trying. My father always says we have to be the best version of us instead of trying to be someone else. I really want to be a Super instead of a Powered. No amount of wishing will make that happen, though, so instead I'm just trying to be a better Powered," Vince said.

"I guess that sort of makes sense," Camille said hesitantly. "Um, this white one is my house."

"Oh, okay," Vince said. "It was nice to meet you, Camy."

"It was. We could hang out again sometime," she ventured hopefully. "What street do you live on?"

“I don’t,” Vince replied. “My father and I are just passing through. I have to go meet him soon, actually. We’re catching a train out of town tonight.”

“Oh. So I won’t see you again?” Camille asked.

“Probably not. The trains don’t come through here too often,” Vince said.

“Well then... thank you again,” she said, heartbreak already seeping in. Her hero, the first real friend she’d had, wouldn’t even be here for one more night. That hurt more than anything Billy or Rick had ever done. That’s when Camille did possibly the first, but by no means the last, brave thing of her life. She whirled around and quickly planted a peck right on Vince’s lips. That accomplished, Camille dashed up the sidewalk to the front door of her house, pausing only briefly to glance back and see his reaction. Vince’s cheeks were bright red, but there was a smile on his face. It nearly matched the one nestled firmly on Camille’s.

Neither knew it, but they were both each other’s first kiss.

\* \* \*

“Hey!” Vince said, snapping his fingers and looking at Camille. “I just remembered where I know you from.”

Camille let out a very soft, very high-pitched squeak and turned bright red.

“You were the healer at Jill and Sasha’s fight, weren’t you?” Vince asked.

Camille slowly nodded her head and prayed the blood would move away from her face sometime soon.

“Ah, great. I knew you looked familiar. That was driving me crazy.”

## 83.

“So, Alice and Mary, this is my roommate, Larry, but we all call him L-Ray, and his best friend, Steve. Steve doesn’t really have a nickname yet,” Bubbles said.

“And I cannot put into words how thankful I am for that,” Steve added.

“Just so I’m clear here, it’s Bubbles, L-Ray, and Steve?” Alice asked, a part of very much hoping she would be corrected.

“Unfortunately, yes,” L-Ray confirmed for her. “It’s nice to meet both of you.”

“Ditto,” Steve agreed.

While Bubbles looked more or less normal for a girl her age, L-Ray stood out significantly more. He wore a skintight purple shirt cut in a long V-neck, snug black jeans that left just a bit too little to the imagination, and purple sneakers. All of this was topped off by black hair with the tips dyed purple and a generous smearing of silver makeup all around his eyes. L-Ray looked even stranger when compared to Steve. Steve was wearing a simple polo, khakis, and sensible shoes. His hair was trimmed in a crew cut and he had the look of a man who definitely knew how to work out and eat right. Neither of the girls would have been surprised to learn he was enrolled in the ROTC program, which he was.

“It’s nice to meet you both as well,” Alice said. “I had a class with Nata- er... Bubbles last semester.”

“Forgive me, but I thought Bubbles said she was introducing us to her roommate,” Mary said.

“She is. I’m her roommate. Turns out Lander is pretty laid back about a co-ed arrangement as long as one of you is gay. I suspect there was a civil suit somewhere along the line,” L-Ray speculated.

“Oh, don’t be silly,” Bubbles said. “I bet they just want everyone to live with the people they have the most fun with. Ooooooh this year will be so awesome and we’ll have so much fun. I’ve already got some awesome plans for the next weekend-”

“That sounds wonderful, darling, but first would you grab us some bottled waters? Just put it on my tab at the bar,” L-Ray asked her.

“Sure thing!” With that Bubble scampered off to wait in a long line of patrons.

“Lovely girl, but I’ve found it’s best to distract her when meeting new people, or else nothing besides opening pleasantries get exchanged,” L-Ray explained once she was gone. “So what are your majors, what year are you, and Mary, can I just say I love your contacts? They go so well with your skin tone.”

“Thank you,” Mary said, not wanting to correct him. Things like her amber eyes or Vince’s hair were often hallmarks of people born with powers. The only blessing was that so many people wanted to be perceived as Supers that such cosmetic versions of these non-human features were almost commonplace, allowing the real ones a bit of room to blend in. There were some who believed this fashion trend had been instigated and kept buoyant by a conspiracy of Supers so they could at least halfway blend in. “I like your eye makeup.”

“Really? I felt like it was a bit over the top, but then again, I saw some guy walking around in here with all of his hair done up in silver, so at least I’m not the most garish one in the room,” L-ray said. “The truth is I prefer to dress a bit more subdued normally, but the makeup is the only part of my outfit that’s mandatory. Thus I figure it’s better to at least appear as if I was going for a specific look. But listen to me, rambling like Bubbles.”

“No, no, it’s interesting,” Alice said. “Why is the makeup mandatory, though?”

“He’s a Powered,” Steve answered for his friend. “He has to wear it pretty much all the time.”

“I’m afraid I still don’t get it,” Alice admitted.

“I have spontaneous x-ray vision,” L-Ray told her. “It just happens at random intervals. The makeup I wear is specially made with lead in it. That way when it kicks on, I can just close my eyes.”

“Right, because eyelids don’t stop x-rays on their own,” Alice said, comprehension dawning.

“And depending on how much you see though, that could be quite a horrifying sight,” Mary added on.

“Exactly,” Steve agreed with them.

“I must say, you’re taking this well. A lot of people get uncomfortable



when they find out I'm a Powered," L-Ray admitted.

Alice and Mary resisted the urge to exchange tell-tale glances. Barely, but they did.

"I guess we're just open-minded," Alice said with a slightly too-large grin.

"So it seems," L-Ray concurred. "Anyway, I believe you were telling us about yourselves."

\* \* \*

"So ladies, which of you wants to take the first sashay around the floor with the dance master?" Nick asked.

"Pass," Violet said.

"No, thank you," Camille replied.

"Lose the shades and maybe we'll talk," Stella shot back.

"No dice, Toots, the shades can be considered welded into my face," Nick said.

"Guess that means you're back to asking some other lady if she wants the pleasure of your company," Vince chuckled. "I'm sure they'll be more receptive to your charms."

"As long as none of them has a Bible on hand," Alex added.

"Wait, what now?" Thomas asked.

"Oh, we haven't told you this story yet?" Alex asked in surprise. "Boy, it's a good one."

"Screw you guys. I'm getting a water at the bar and picking up some girl with self-esteem issues. You'll see, next time your eyes fall on Nick Campbell it will be as a gorgeous woman swoons into his arms," Nick declared, half walking, half storming off back inside.

"You think we were too mean?" Vince said, suddenly concerned.

"Nah, Nick loves having all eyes on him. Hell, sometimes I think he messes up with girls on purpose just for the stories. Trust me on this one, he's feeling just fine," Alex assured him.

Vince decided to take his word for it, because while Alex might not have Mary's precision, he was more than capable of picking up on feelings.

“So, what now?” Hershel asked.

“Much as Nick can be a bit peculiar in his methods, I say we take his idea and go dance,” Violet said. “Thomas, would you care to start me off, for old times’ sake?”

“Of course,” Thomas replied with a gentlemanly nod of his head.

“No way I’m sitting that out,” Stella declared. “Hershel, your other persona seems to have some moves. Want to do a spin on the floor?”

“Sure, I guess so,” Hershel reluctantly agreed. He would have rather been dancing with Mary, but he didn’t see the strength of will to make that happen coming anytime soon. Besides, this seemed innocent enough.

“Only one girl left,” Alex pointed out. “Vince, if you don’t mind, can I steal her away?”

“Sure thing,” Vince replied. “I really don’t feel right dancing with someone besides my girlfriend anyway.”

“Um... well... I...” Camille said, hesitating. She really didn’t have any urge to go gyrate on the dance floor with some man she barely knew. Then again, the other option was staying here with Vince, possibly alone if Alex decided to search for another partner. As soon as that thought raced into her head, the decision was made.

“That sounds lovely.”

\* \* \*

“-and that’s how I decided to major in geology,” L-Ray finished explaining.

“Eeeeeeeee!” Bubble squealed, dashing up to their cluster and passing out waters.

“Sweet heaven, I think my eardrum just killed itself,” Steve complained.

“Calm down, darling, what’s got you in such a tizzy?” L-Ray said, working with more patience than Alice believed she could have mustered under such auditory assault.

“OhmygodItotallysawthatguyandhewas-”

“Spaces, Bubbles. I need spaces between the words to understand them,” L-Ray instructed her.

Bubble took a few deep, rapid breaths and tried again. “You know that really cute guy I told you about that I see around campus who looks really cool and fun and all well I was up there getting the water and he got in line just a few people behind me and he’s still there and what should I do?”

“Well, that was better. No punctuation, but then I didn’t ask for any, so I’ve only got myself to blame,” L-Ray said. “Just go up and talk to him. You’re an adorable girl, I’m sure he’d love to meet and hit on you.”

“I don’t know, he’s really cute. I bet girls come up to him all the time and I bet I’m not as pretty by comparison,” Bubbles said uncertainly.

“Which guy is it?” Alice asked, trying to see through the throngs of people at the bar.

“He’s wearing a green shirt, jeans, and these awesome sunglasses,” Bubbles told her.

“Wait, sunglasses?” Sure enough, Nick was by the bar, a bottle of cold water pressed to his lips and the standard shades still in place. The next words out of Alice’s mouth were a prime example of how the tongue can rush forward before the brain’s diplomatic instincts have any chance to intervene.

“You have got to be fucking kidding me.”

## 84.

“She’s surprised at the coincidence,” Mary said quickly. “That guy you were talking about is a friend of ours named Nick.”

“Oh holy crap, really? You know him? Be honest with me: does he already have a girlfriend or is he just playing the field?” Bubbles asked.

“Him? Really? Him?” Alice said.

“Yes, she’s talking about our friend,” Mary assured her. “Such coincidences do happen. And Bubbles, he is still single, to the very best of my knowledge.”

“That is so awesome! You have to introduce me, will you please introduce me? Every time I see him on campus I totally want to say something but I just think it’d seem so desperate. Pretty please introduce us.”

“Every time you see him?” Alice said once more, her mind still not congealing the facts being presented to her.

“I would love to introduce you,” Mary said. “Just come with me.”

“Cute? Him? *Really?*”

\* \* \*

“We don’t have to dance much if you don’t want to,” Alex told Camille once they had put a significant distance between themselves and Vince. “I just thought you might like an exit.”

“What are you talking-” Camille began to ask, then basic memory function kicked in. “Right. You’re the other telepath in the class.”

“I’m not a... look, that isn’t important,” Alex said patiently. “The point is, I had a sense of how uncomfortable you were feeling and I wanted to help.”

“Thank you,” Camille said sincerely.

“If you’re in the mood, though, I wouldn’t mind a little dancing,” Alex added.

“I think that would be okay,” Camille agreed, oddly more comfortable with this boy despite that fact that her mental privacy had been a bit violated.

“I should also mention that while I don’t know what makes you so

uneasy around Vince, there's no need to be. I can promise you he's a really good guy."

Camille wasn't quite able to stop herself from glancing over her shoulder at Vince's silhouette against the too-bright lights of the club.

"I know."

\* \* \*

"Hey, Nick, this is my friend, Bubbles," Mary said, approaching him.

"Hey, Mary. Hi, Bubbles. Interesting name, story I should be aware of?"

"Hi, Nick. Nice to meet you. I really like your sunglasses. Why do wear them indoors, though? Is it a prescription thing? My mom does that when her contacts fall out or when she loses her normal pair or wants to look pretty because she thinks they make her look like Audrey Hepburn even though they don't but no one tells her 'cause we love her."

"You know what, I think I can put the pieces together myself," Nick said. He looked over this new girl. She was yappy, that was pretty much the definition of evident. She was chipper, though, and that was a plus. Happy people asked fewer questions and demanded less attention, or so he'd found. It didn't hurt that she was cute, too. Tall, with chestnut brown hair and not easily ignorable curves to her body. Not to mention she was clearly at a ridiculous level of into him. This would work.

"Bubbles, I don't mean to be forward, but would you like to dance?" Nick asked casually.

"Yes!" She grabbed his hand and began pulling him toward to the room where the music was blasting.

It wasn't a perfect situation; Nick would freely admit that. She couldn't talk over the music, though, and he had made the boast that he would next be on the floor with a beautiful woman. It could have been worse.

Meanwhile Mary, having been almost immediately abandoned, made her way back over to the others.

"That went fast," Steve commented.

"What Nick lacks in game he makes up for in luck," Mary said truthfully. Admittedly, the discrepancy was a much different ratio than those who couldn't read his mind might guess, but the statement was still basically

honest.

“She was into Nick,” Alice said, still somewhat coming to terms with the idea.

“It was bound to happen eventually,” Steve said. “Your friend is pretty good looking.”

“I... how am I missing this?” Alice asked uncertainly.

“Uh huh. While little miss not-big-on-facing-the-obvious wraps her head around some truth, you ladies want to keep an eye on them on the dance floor?” L-Ray asked. “At least you know we won’t try to cop a feel.”

“We?” Mary said. “I mean, I know you’re gay, but I didn’t know Steve was.”

“Gay as a Broadway musical ensemble,” Steve assured her. “We don’t all fit the stereotypes.”

Mary blushed. She was getting so used to her telepathy that she found herself making serious social blunders without it. “I’m sorry. That was insensitive and stupid of me.”

Steve patted her shoulder. “Nothing to worry about. It happens all the time. L-Ray is a little more flamboyant than I am, and that tends to draw the attention of most people’s gaydar.”

“I’m still sorry,” Mary repeated. “But I’d love to take you both up on your offer. Let’s go cut a rug.”

L-Ray laughed. “Oh, you are just precious.”

\* \* \*

So it was that everyone except Vince, Will, and Jill found themselves on the dance floor. The sweaty, stuffed with people, assaulted by a symphony of screeching, dance floor. Still, it was contact with the opposite sex, albeit only a swiveling of hips and awkward placing of hands. It was a mash of friends, some old and some new, just trying to enjoy themselves in an environment designed for other things. It was even a little fun, too.

Pretty much everyone was terrible at the act of dancing, so no one knew how bad their particular partner was, Nick and Violet being the exceptions. They had natural rhythm and training, so they knew their particular partners sucked, but they pressed on anyway. There was no conversation to be had on the floor, only meaningful glances and more than

one game of poorly-played charades. In a way this was a blessing, for if any word exchange had been possible things might have played out differently.

Hershel had been dancing with Stella for a few minutes when Nick and Bubbles wandered in. Hershel had to tip a mental hat to his friend; he'd come through on returning with a hottie in hand. Then he noticed the pair that had followed them in and begun dancing. By luck of the draw Mary had wound up dancing with Steve, whose broad shoulders and square jaw told the story of a powerful man. A man who was capable and strong, who could get things done. In other words, a man who had all the qualities Hershel only experienced vicariously through Roy.

Hershel's heart sank. He should have asked her when he had the chance. Now this guy would dance with her all night. After all, who would be stupid enough to let Mary get away? Well, besides him. No, this guy would charm and woo her, then ask her out at the end of the night. They'd start a long lasting relationship, get married, and Hershel would never see that window of opportunity open again. It was over; he'd missed his shot.

Then something stirred within Hershel he hadn't felt since he was stranded on the mountain. Sheer, stupid desperation. Roy hadn't been there to help him. His only way out had been to press on no matter what. It was a situation where all he could do was try and move upward, because there was no other option. He didn't know why, but somehow it was the same now. He had to try.

There was no other option.

Hershel made a polite series of hand gestures to Stella, then began shoving his way through the crowd. It was hard, vaguely disgusting work due to all the sweat. He parted the sea of bodies swimming in sound, step by difficult step. He reached Mary and Steve just as the song was changing. Briefly he contemplated abandoning this foolishness and running like hell. Instead he tapped Mary on the shoulder.

She turned around and looked up at him. Mary wasn't even bothering to try and read minds with the noise smashing all around her, but when she looked up at Hershel, she didn't need to. What he wanted couldn't have been any clearer. She looked at Steve, mouthed the words "Thank you for the dance" and then stepped into the arms of her new partner. In the grand scheme of things it really wasn't very much.

But it was progress.

## 85.

“All right, ladies and gentlemen, today we take the first steps toward mastering the fine art of battle,” Coach George said. It was Monday afternoon and the combat class was back in the same room as they had been on Friday. The debris has mostly been cleaned up, though a keen eye could still spot a few remaining signs along the ground.

“Not surprisingly, this will start with learning how to fight,” Coach George continued. “Now, I’ll take a minute here to make sure I’m clear. When I say fight, I don’t mean zip around, or turn the ground into fudge, or any other such bullcrap. That’s called strategy, and that comes later. When I say fight, what I mean is the ability to get the crap kicked out of you and the strength to knock the teeth out of someone’s head, which incidentally will be a test later in the year.”

Some of the students exchanged worried glances. A few days ago they would have assumed he was joking, but after Friday...

“We’re talking about today, though, and this will be the same thing we do for the next several months, so I’d pay attention if I were you. The procedure is simple. I’ll call you out in pairs. You’ll find one of the many red circles located on the ground in this room. You’ll both step in the circle. You’ll beat each other senseless until the end of class. You’ll go get healed and come back fresh next time. Wash, rinse, repeat.”

“What exactly does this teach us?” Stella asked from her place in line.

“Two hundred pushups for speaking without being called on,” Coach George snapped at her. “That kind of crap might fly in the dean’s class, but I think you’ll find me a lecturer much less appreciative of interaction.”

Stella looked like she was ready to object for a moment, but her eyes wandered to one of the scorch marks from the last class’s brawl. A brawl in which she’d been trounced with ease. She got down and began doing the reps.

“Since Hawkins was smart enough to take her lumps and shut her mouth, I’ll answer her question,” Coach George resumed. “This is teaching you all the basics of fighting. Not the movements, not the reflexes, not the martial arts, the real basics. Hit and get hit. Be hurt and push through. Feel the painful impact of your knuckles on another person’s bones. Those are the lessons you can only learn through experience. Now, I know some of you have had those lessons firsthand already, but these are ones you can never really have too much of. So for now you learn to fight. Once you’ve all got



that down pat, then we move on to how to win.”

Coach George examined the students looking back at him. They were a little worried, most of them seemed to still feel confident, though. After all, they were warriors and this was sparring. How bad could it be?

"I do have a few rules you should know about, though. First off is that if you get knocked out of the circle, your opponent will get to take a penalty shot at your face, a shot you will not dodge or block. Secondly is that I'm the one who determines your opponent each day, so don't bother me with requests. Sometimes you'll fight people better than you, sometimes worse, but I'll be keeping careful track of how you all do and making my choices to maximize everyone's education. Third, the fights go on until the end of class. If you're knocked unconscious, we'll grab you a healer and you'll get back at it. I don't care how much you ache or how tired you are; you fight to the end, no exceptions. Fourth is the last rule, the most important rule, and my personal favorite rule."

A large, unsettling smile crept across Coach George's face.

"No powers."

\* \* \*

"I trust everyone completed the weekend's assignment," Coach Persephone said as the students fell into line.

There was a mumbling to the affirmative that was to be expected. Alice, for once, didn't shoot her hand up to volunteer as an example. For some reason she'd felt all out of sorts since Friday night, unable to really focus on the assignment and come up with a cool experiment. She'd ultimately settled on trying to levitate just one part of herself, specifically her hair, Sunday evening. It had been even less successful than it was interesting or impressive.

"Rich Weaver," Coach Persephone called out, pointing to a dark-haired boy with a goatee. "In what new way did you try to use your power?"

"I tried to seal a cat in its own mind," Rich replied promptly. "I've never tried it on animals before."

"Not much in the way of a new technique, but it was an honest attempt," Coach Persephone said. "Did it work?"

"I'm not really sure," Rich admitted. "The cat just sat there and stared at me, but it was doing that beforehand, too. Next time I think I'll try a more

active animal.”

“Good idea,” Coach Persephone agreed. “Britney Fletcher, what was your attempt?”

“I tried to make a force field,” Britney said.

Coach Persephone blinked in surprise. “I was under the impression your power was invisibility.”

“It is.”

“Then what would make you think that would in any way lend itself to sustaining a maintained field of defensive energy?” Coach Persephone asked.

Britney shrugged in response. “You said try something really different.”

“You overshot the goal a bit there, dear,” Coach Persephone told her. “All right, let’s move on to Nick Campbell. I trust after our little talk on Friday you decided to give your homework a try?”

“I did indeed,” Nick said. “I tried to use my power in a whole new way.”

“Do tell.”

“I tried to get laid,” Nick stated proudly. The silence that followed his statements lasted several seconds. Seconds that consisted of the others looking at him with a mix of entertainment, curiosity, and disgust from those who suspected the worst. Unfortunately, Coach Persephone’s particular expression fell into the last category. Nick at last acknowledged the stares by looking around and raising his hands.

“What’d I say?”

“You attempted to use your power, the thing that makes you a Super and places you in a class of elite beings more capable than any mere human, for sexual gratification?” Coach Persephone asked in a very strained voice.

“Dick’s not going to suck itself,” Nick replied.

“You used your gift to try and manipulate some unsuspecting girl into intercourse, and you have so little remorse you can make flippant jokes about it? Nick Campbell, I am very close to hurling you out of this class right now,” Coach Persephone threatened.

“Do what you have to do,” Nick replied. “But let’s get something

straight. I did the assignment. I didn't do anything illicit or manipulative, though. At our age sex is eighty percent pure chance of opportunity. I used my luck to heighten the probability of meeting a girl who found me to be a viable and desirable partner. No influence on anything but sheer chance. It was a valid attempt to try my power in a new way. I mean, hell's bells, another term for sex is 'getting lucky.' I did exactly what you told me, lady, so don't go getting too high on your soapbox."

Coach Persephone's lips were pressed into a thin line. The students nearest to Nick began edging away, just in case she let loose with more of the twitching on the floor power. Instead she released a long, deep breath.

"Were you successful?" Coach Persephone asked.

"Yes and no," Nick said. "I probably could have been, but it turns out just finding someone who wants you doesn't mean you'll want them too."

"True. Good job. And one more thing."

"Yes ma'am?" Nick asked.

"You were right in that I was jumping to conclusions on what you'd done. You were also right to fully explain yourself before I acted. However, speak to me in a tone that disrespectful again and I'll leave you a drooling piss-soaked mess on the floor," Coach Persephone said with surprising evenness to her tone.

"Noted," Nick said.

\* \* \*

Coach George could see the desire to speak, to argue, to be contrary in the face of what he'd just told them. Hawkins was still on the floor pounding out her push-ups, though, and that was an audible reminder that unwarranted comments were not appreciated in his class.

"I know some of you are wondering why I would do this. Others of you have already put it together. For the sake of you dumber students I'll explain. You're going to fight people who are stronger and faster than you eventually. Right now I want you learning to fight at a base level. Powers come later, once you've proven you're competent enough to handle them. We'll use them, just not until you're ready. Any questions?"

No one raised their hand. They were learning slowly, but they were learning.

"Good. When I call your names, grab your partner and get in a circle.

Once everyone is assigned, the circles will glow red. Start smacking the shit out of each other and don't stop until those bastards go dark. Clear?"

"Yes, sir!" This was yelled by a large majority of the students, almost instinctually. Coach George loved the sound of that chorus. It meant he was forging order from the chaos.

"Excellent. Castillo and Reid, pair up. Foster and Dixon. Riley and Wells. Reynolds and DeSoto," Coach said, rambling off the names. He read quickly, leaving no doubt in his students' minds that they were expected to move with just as much speed. There was a scramble as the students searched through somewhat familiar faces, trying to find their opponent and get inside a square as rapidly as their bodies would permit. Before long Coach George had reached the end.

"Sullivan, grab Hawkins when she's done with her push-ups. Lastly, Daniels and Taylor report to me," Coach George finished. Roy and Chad looked at each other with some confusion, but neither had any more idea of why they'd been singled out than the other.

"Okay everyone, you have five minutes before your circles glow. Shake hands, stretch, pray, or do whatever revs you up before a fight. I'll be here watching when it starts, so make sure you come out swinging," Coach George instructed them. He then turned his attention to Roy and Chad.

"You two follow me. I have a special place for you to fight."

\* \* \*

"Here's the deal," Coach George said once they had arrived at an even lower level. This one was as bare as the last, though on the ground were a series of red rings, each one within the last until the final ring that was only five feet across. "You two are now permanent training buddies. Shake hands, make nice, and find peace with it."

"Works for me," Roy said with a grin. "But why am I the only one who gets to pound on Blondie?"

"Because, dumbass, you have to use your powers when you train. It doesn't do Roy any good if Hershel is the one learning the lessons," Coach George explained. "And Taylor here has remodeled his whole body from the ground up. He can't really just turn that shit on and off in the blink of eye. It works out, though, because you're both strong enough to ring each other's bells."

"I don't feel this will be adequate training for me," Chad said. "He

doesn't offer me a significant challenge or the opportunity for learning."

"Try letting him smash you in the face and work on your pain tolerance," Coach George snapped at him. "It's what we've got to work with, so I suggest you find a way to get some gain from it."

"I'll do my best," Chad replied.

"Goody for you. Now, you two are going to start in the smallest circle. I have to be back upstairs to watch the others so I'll review tapes of your training at night. When I think the time is right, we'll move you to bigger circles."

"Aw, why bother with that bullshit?" Roy complained.

"Because given enough room to move around, Taylor would utterly crush you at your current skill level like he did a few months ago. At least in close proximity you stand a chance of hitting a lucky blow," Coach George told him.

Roy thought about yapping off again, then reconsidered. He really couldn't have asked for better circumstances. He was training against the strongest guy in class every single day. There was no better way for him to improve than this.

"Fine, I guess it'll do," Roy said, walking toward the center circle.

\* \* \*

"It's Shane, right?" Vince asked as he and his opponent stared at other from within their circle.

"Right. And you're Vince, the guy who can absorb energy," Shane replied.

"Bingo."

"Nice ability. Not to mention you must have some exceptional combat skills," Shane continued.

"Thanks, I think. What makes you say that, though?"

"You were beaten in the first round but you still made eighth rank. You've fended off Michael multiple times despite his presence in the top three. And then of course there's the fact that you're fighting me," Shane explained.

"I take it you're good too, then," Vince said, catching his meaning

immediately.

“If not for the experience of fighting Chad I would have thought myself easily the best in our year,” Shane told him.

“I have heard he’s pretty talented,” Vince said.

“Talent has nothing to do with it. Chad Taylor is a man possessed. I’ve been working to be a Hero since I was a small child. I’ve been instructed in various forms of martial arts and had the opportunity to hone my power to a level of refinement it would take the others in this class years to match. And I still cannot match the intensity with which Chad trains for battle,” Shane said. “He lives and breathes it. His free time is spent thinking of new strategies and techniques. Even when he’s resting he trains new reflex sequences into his muscles. It is literally his entire life.”

“Wow, that’s amazing,” Vince said. “And kind of sad. I mean, there’s more to life than just fighting.”

“Perhaps. But he is the best, and we are not. So maybe we’re the ones who’ve taken a wrong turn,” Shane pointed out.

Vince would have said more, but the soft hum from behind him was the only warning he got that the circle was beginning to glow.

“Good luck,” Vince said.

“Move swiftly and surely,” Shane replied.

\* \* \*

The first clash lasted only seconds. Before Roy could even blink, Chad had drilled him in the ribs and knocked him on his back. He didn’t press the attack, surprisingly. Instead he took a few steps back and allowed Roy to climb to his feet.

“Thanks,” Roy said as he rose. “But you didn’t have to do that.”

“Kicking you mercilessly while you lie on the ground isn’t really a great learning experience for either of us,” Chad said.

“True,” Roy agreed, rushing him. Chad slid out of the way with ease, catching Roy’s shoulder and putting him right back on the ground. Roy pulled himself up again.

“Listen, I don’t do this often, but something’s been bugging me,” Roy said once he was up.

This time Chad stepped forward and caught Roy in the sternum, sweeping out his legs at the same time.

“What’s that?” Chad asked as he looked down.

“I wanted to say I’m sorry,” Roy replied, rubbing his chest as he got on his feet. “I’m sorry I insulted your power before. I still think mine is stronger, but I’ll admit yours is a lot more impressive than I would have guessed.”

Chad closed the gap between them and punched Roy in the jaw. As Roy’s head reeled to the side, Chad grabbed his right arm and hurled him over his shoulder. This time he didn’t just land on the ground, he was slammed there with an impact that left concrete chips on his shirt.

“Apology accepted,” Chad said in his usual even tone.

\* \* \*

Vince and Shane were both dripping in sweat as they gasped for air, circling one another.

“You’re better than I expected,” Shane complimented him.

“You, too,” Vince agreed.

Each boy was covered in small gashes and bruises. They’d put each other down several times and taken the fight to the concrete more than once, but neither had managed to get so much of an advantage that he could own the day. Plus, they had been unable to drive each other out of the ring even a single time.

“You look tired,” Vince told him.

“You look exhausted,” Shane replied.

“I think the others are about out of gas,” Vince noted, watching the lackluster battles around the room. It might not have been so bad if they hadn’t done the usual two hours of hard training before this part of class.

“That your way of asking me if we can softball it ‘til the clock runs out?”

“Not in the slightest,” Vince replied. He dashed forward, sweeping at Shane’s legs. Shane stepped back on his right foot, bringing his left swinging for Vince’s head. Vince moved his whole body with the blow, doing a half flip only a few inches above the ground and driving his legs into Shane’s chest. Shane dropped to his knees rather than have the momentum send him sailing

out of the ring, and both boys scrambled to get to their feet.

“Not bad,” Vince said to Shane as they both sucked in air.

“I was thinking the same thing,” Shane replied.

\* \* \*

“You’ve gotten better since last time,” Chad told Roy as Roy dragged himself from the ground.

“I get better hang time in the air?”

“No, you’re thinking when you come at me now. And your reflexes have improved. Not much, but some. You’ve been learning some martial arts,” Chad said.

“Guilty,” Roy replied, swaying slightly. “Lot of good it’s done me.” He hadn’t landed a blow on Chad yet, and Chad was hammering away at him every time they came together. Roy was resistant to damage, of course; however, Chad dished out enough to cover that gap and more. In truth, Roy knew the only reason he was still conscious was simply because Chad didn’t want to knock him out, and that knowledge made him want to crush that blond bastard even harder.

“It’s a process. You should keep that in mind. Steady groundwork is what bears results,” Chad told him.

“I’ll make sure to remember,” Roy replied, stumbling forward. He was too slow, he knew it as soon as he was moving. Chad would capitalize. Sure enough, rather than use a quick series of blows to knock Roy down, Chad instead took a step forward and smashed him in the forehead with a powerful kick. Roy saw static all around him, and when his vision finally cleared, he was on the ground again. It was beginning to have a familiar, almost homey feel.

“Just stay down already,” Chad told him. “I’ll go fetch a healer and we can tell Coach George that this won’t work because you can’t keep up with me. By this time tomorrow we’ll both have people more appropriate to our skill level.”

“Fuck you,” Roy spat out, along with a bit of blood.

“I beg your pardon? I was trying to show you mercy.”

“You were trying to show me condescension,” Roy sneered, getting up for what felt like the billionth agonizing time. “Yeah, you’re faster than I am,



and more skilled than I am, and a hell of a lot better practiced than I am, but who cares?”

“Off handedly, I’d say your battered body. Don’t get the wrong idea here, Roy. I’ve been going easy on you. This can get much worse.”

“Blondie, there’s a few things you should know about me,” Roy said as he found his shaky footing. “I love whiskey, dumb blondes, and my momma. I don’t welch on bets and I don’t cheat at pool. And I never, repeat, never give up.” Roy locked eyes with Chad and gave him the legendary Daniels’ family grin. “Now bring it the fuck on.”

To his credit, Roy stayed conscious for the rest of the fight, even if a part of him truly wished he hadn’t.

## 86.

“Yeesh, this guy took one hell of a pounding,” said the healer, a female junior. Roy could make out the words dimly over the ringing in his ears.

“That’s what she said,” snickered a male voice next to her.

“Damn it, Ed, that doesn’t even make sense. Try to show a little respect,” the girl snapped at him. “Just because he’s passed out doesn’t mean you can act like a jackass.”

She was wrong; Roy was still awake. He could hear them after all. It wasn’t worth the effort to correct her, though. Not right now.

“Sorry, sorry,” Ed apologized. “I just get kind of weirded out being too somber around people this messed up. I don’t want to treat them like they’re already dead or something.”

“No worries on that for this one. He’s already healing up on his own. To be this hearty and still be so pummeled... it must have been one hell of a beating,” the girl commented.

“Maybe he wasn’t fighting back,” Ed suggested.

“No way,” the girl told him. “Didn’t you notice all the impact wounds? This guy kept getting up over and over and getting put right back down. He was obviously outclassed, but I’ll give him one thing. He did not want to lose.”

Roy’s head swam and he finally lost the tenuous grip to consciousness he had been clutching so adamantly.

\* \* \*

“Thank you for coming, Mrs. Daniels,” the principal said, raising from his desk and shaking her hand. “Will Mr. Daniels be joining us?”

“I’m afraid he’s out of town at the moment,” Mrs. Daniels said. “His construction company got a job down in Florida that he’s overseeing.”

“Ah, I understand,” the principal said. “In that case I suppose we can begin. Please, have a seat.”

“Not that I’m not eager to find out why you called me down here so urgently, but shouldn’t you excuse the student already here before we talk?”

Mrs. Daniels asked. She glanced at the small plastic chair he was sitting in, reclined back and feet swinging freely.

"I'm afraid that boy is actually part of the reason you were called down," the principal said hesitantly.

"Was he in a fight with my son? I know Hershel has been getting bullied since we moved here."

"Not exactly. You see, that boy sitting in that chair is your son. Sort of. I'm afraid it's somewhat complicated, Mrs. Daniels. Are you sure you wouldn't rather have a seat?"

Mrs. Daniels didn't take the open chair. Instead she walked over to the small boy and got on her knees. She looked him in the eye for a long time, long enough that the boy began to squirm uncomfortably.

"What's your name?"

"Dunno," the boy replied.

"Do you know I am?"

"Mommy," the boy replied.

"Are you Hershel?" she asked.

The boy shook his head. "Hershel was crying cause they kept making fun of him. He couldn't make them stop, so I did."

"For the record, 'stopping them' consisted of several children with extensive bruising and an overturned jungle gym," the principal interjected.

"Is that true? Did you hurt the other children?"

The boy looked down at the floor. "It was an accident. They wouldn't stop making Hershel cry. I just wanted to stop them."

"I understand. Well, we'll have to get you some help in learning to stop people without hurting them," Mrs. Daniels said, giving the boy a reassuring squeeze of his hand, then standing up to her full height.

"I must say, Mrs. Daniels, you're taking this all very well," the principal commented.

"My aunt was a Super, so I've always known it might run in our blood," Mrs. Daniels lied.

"I'm afraid you must know that until Hershel can control his powers

more effectively, he won't be able to attend our facility anymore," the principal said hesitantly.

"Of course," Mrs. Daniels agreed. "I fully intend to get my son, or perhaps I should say sons, the education they need to become happy, integrated Supers."

"Sons? Mrs. Daniels, that boy is still Hershel. It's just him utilizing his abilities," the principal told her.

This time it was Mrs. Daniels who shook her head. "That boy isn't Hershel," she said matter-of-factly. "But he is definitely my son." She looked back at the boy and smiled at him. "On that note, I suppose we should find a good name for you."

"Mrs. Daniels, I don't think you--"

\* \* \*

Roy was jerked awake by a coughing fit. He hacked and thundered for several minutes before lying back down on the table.

"Sorry about that, big guy," said the girl in a soft, comforting voice. "It's a side effect of when we heal around the lungs."

Roy heard her and understood. He didn't care, though; now that he'd tasted sleep he wasn't ready to stop gorging on it just yet.

\* \* \*

He could hear her crying again through the walls. She would only do it when she thought he was outside, and even then only into a pillow to muffle the sound. It wasn't muffled quite enough. She was crying so often these days. Because she missed him.

Roy's fists clenched involuntarily. He got so mad whenever he thought about his dad. Mad at him for leaving and mad at himself for missing him. Last week Roy had finally managed to lift a pickup truck in the junkyard where he and his dad used to work out. His first instinct had been to run and proudly tell his father of the accomplishment. Then Roy had remembered.

"He has some things to work out," his mother had told him, choking back her own sadness. "Things he needs space for."

Roy forced himself to let his hands loosen. It didn't make any sense. His dad had always said a man lived up to responsibilities, he took care of those in need, he helped the weak. But he could walk out on his own family

like it was nothing?

Roy steadied himself. She needed him to be strong right now. Besides, Roy already had a plan. He'd find that son-of-a-bitch one day and ask him in person why he'd walked out. And if he didn't have the world's best answer, Roy was going to beat him mercilessly. That was later, though; his dad was still the better fighter between them. For now.

He knocked gently on the door. "Mom," he called. "Are you okay?"

\* \* \*

"-looks like he'll be fine," the girl said.

"Glad to hear it," Coach George's gruff voice said, echoing through the room.

"Good thing he's hearty," Ed said. "I can't imagine what he did to deserve a beating like he got."

"He's tenacious," Coach George said. "More so than I was expecting, to be honest. When I paired him with Taylor I figured it would be his last day in program."

"Looks like he surprised you," the girl said.

"That he did," Coach George admitted. "But there's always tomorrow."

\* \* \*

Roy wasn't sure what to feel. Rage? Betrayal? Mostly it was just confusion, but the other two were percolating there as well. He sat silently in his bus seat, staring out the window and trying hard not to think. He could feel the stares of some of the other passengers. A thirteen-year-old boy traveling alone tended to attract attention, after all. On the way out here he'd felt self-conscious about that fact. Now he didn't give two shits what people were thinking about him.

All these years he'd dreamed of the day he confronted his father. All these years he'd trained and worked and sweat for the sake of being better than him. He'd spent days tracking him down, and then when he finally found him...

Roy shook his head. He couldn't deal with it, couldn't see his dad that way. But the image was there, festering in the back of his mind, unwilling to purge itself despite all his efforts.

Roy felt Hershel stirring within him. They'd been switching even more erratically than normal lately. It was possible stress was a factor in their condition. Roy didn't care at the moment. Right now he just wanted to be alone. Truly alone, not just one half of a whole. He was barely holding it together as it was, and now he realized he had his little brother to worry about, too. It was just too much.

"Simmer down, Fatso," Roy whispered hotly under his breath. "Nobody fucking wants you here right now."

## 87.

Roy was surprised to open his eyes. He'd thought Hershel would have taken over by now. He was still in the resting room where the healers worked. He slowly pulled himself to a sitting position and looked around.

"Careful," Mary cautioned. "You're all patched up but you might be woozy for a while."

She was sitting in a chair a few feet away. There were several books with her, one cracked open in her lap.

"What are you doing here?" Roy asked, a twinge of harshness in his voice.

"I was keeping watch. I wanted to make sure you were okay," Mary said.

"So kind of you," Roy snapped. "I'll tell Hershel you cared. You can run along now."

"I don't think you understand. I was here checking on you, on Roy. I heard what happened," Mary explained.

"That I got my ass kicked? Come on, I'm not really a delicate flower and we have healers on call at all times. There was literally nothing to worry about," Roy scoffed, swinging his feet over the edge of the bed and standing up.

Mary shook her head. "Not the fight. I heard what happened after."

"What do you mean?"

"The memories."

Roy felt himself become very still. "You listened to those?"

"Not intentionally, no. They were the psychic equivalent of throat-tearing screams, though. They overwhelmed everything around me. They seemed... intense," Mary said.

Roy tried to calm himself, a task made more difficult by the same memory dreams they were discussing.

"Shit happens," Roy said. "No sense dwelling on it. I'm fine."

"No, you're not," Mary disagreed. "You're harboring a lot of anger

inside. I think that's why you lashed out at so much of the world and distanced yourself. It's all anger you feel toward your fath-

She was cut off by the crashing sound of Roy's bed being slammed to the ground courtesy of Roy's fist.

"You and I are not friends," Roy said coldly. "You won a bet against me and I'm honoring the deal. That's it. I do not need, or want, or care about your advice. And if you ever mention my father again, then all bets are off between us. Understood?"

Mary nodded slowly. "That's fair, I suppose. To me, and maybe to you, but certainly not to Hershel. I guess that's between brothers, though." She reached down and began scooping up her books. "One thing I should point out: I don't know what you went through."

"No argument here," Roy said.

"But that doesn't mean nobody here does. If you were to talk to people a little more you might find others you could share the burden with."

"Please, I talk to more people than any of you social rejects."

"No, you don't. You slap hands, you exchange drinks, you have a few laughs. You don't talk to anyone, you don't bond with anyone, you don't connect with anyone," Mary told him.

"I'm connecting all over the place," Roy shot back.

Mary finished gathering her books and stood up from the chair.

"Of course you are. That's why this room is so stuffed with people who wanted to make sure you were okay," Mary said, turning on her heel and heading out the door.

Roy looked around at the empty room and the broken bed. He tried to think of a joke he could make about breaking the bed, preferably one that implied he had tremendous genitalia. Nothing really came to mind. Instead he found his shoes and walked out a different door.

\* \* \*

"Roy!"

Roy was only a few feet down the hallway, headed back to the lifts, when a familiar voice called to him. He looked over his shoulder to see none other than the man who had just beaten him senseless jogging up to him.



“Hello, Chad,” Roy greeted hesitantly.

“Hello,” Chad replied. “I see you’re moving around again.”

“I’m a quick heal,” Roy replied.

“I’m sure,” Chad said. “I wanted to talk to you about today.”

“Was there something left unsaid by our fists?”

“Actually, yes, at least on my end,” Chad said. “I was thinking about our fight while you were getting healed. Specifically about how hopelessly out of your league you are when you fight me, yet how you continued to try.”

“Gee, thanks, but I kind of already got the memo that I suck compared to you,” Roy said.

“You do; but that isn’t the point. The point is that you kept coming at me; you kept trying no matter how hard I put you down. I realized that the kind of man who can withstand the punishment I’m capable of dishing out and then ask for more is a man with a lot of determination.”

“Well... yeah, actually,” Roy agreed.

“I can relate with that sort of mindset,” Chad said. “So I came to a conclusion. I won’t improve at all by fighting you. You, on the other hand, will improve tremendously if you can continue to fight like you did today. And in the grand scheme of things, one hour per day helping a similar individual reach their goal is something I can tolerate.”

“I guess you’re saying you want to stay sparring partners,” Roy surmised.

“Yes. I’ll keep entering the ring with you for as long as Coach George deems necessary. That is, of course, on the condition that your dedication and intensity do not drop,” Chad explained.

“That part you don’t need to worry about,” Roy said. “And... um... thanks, I guess.”

“Glad to help,” Chad replied. He turned and began to walk away.

“Hey, Chad,” Roy called out.

“Yes?”

“You said you got the same power as your dad. Is he a Hero?”

Chad nodded without looking back. “He was one of the greatest

Heroes ever to live. Why?”

“Just curious, I guess,” Roy lied. “You’re a strong guy. I thought someone else with your power would have been a pretty famous Hero if he was in the business.”

“He is still very famous. Just not for the reasons he deserves,” Chad said. “I’ll see you tomorrow, Roy.”

“See you then,” Roy told Chad’s exiting form. See, he could connect with people. What the hell did Mary know, anyway?

## 88.

As the days slipped by, even as something as strange as a daily bare-knuckle brawl became little more than a piece of routine for the combat students. The alternative training course posed different challenges. It was a mishmash of light sparring, discussion, and “mind exercises.” These challenges presented by Coach Persephone could be as simple as a riddle or as complex as an intricate battle scenario where one was expected to provide a step by step plan for victory. The riddles were, on the whole, considered the more popular task.

They, too, settled into a rhythm, and soon spring was beginning to slip subtle touches onto the landscape. It was a flower here, a green patch of grass there, things that showed winter was losing its stronghold on the terrain. Of course, some signs were less subtle than others.

“Freshman River Trip. March 18 – March 22. Final sign up date February 2,” Vince read from the flyer posted on the door to Dean Blaine’s classroom. He turned and looked at some of the other students who had pooled behind him. “Anyone know what this is?”

“My sister told me about it,” Shane volunteered. “It’s a big event during spring break for the freshman class. They provide transportation, tents, and tubes for us to float the river on.”

Vince shuddered involuntarily. Ever since the mountain he’d gotten a spike of cold every time he thought about camping.

“Apparently it’s also tradition for the sophomores chaperoning to bring tons of beer and liquor so that the whole weekend is quite the celebratory event,” Shane continued.

“Great,” Vince said unenthusiastically. That made it sound even less fun. There was nothing that seemed even remotely appealing about this trip.

“Hells yeah. I’m putting our names at the top of the list,” Sasha said, stepping forward and plucking a pen from her bag. “About time we get to have some fun. I’m still kicking myself for missing that sophomore party last semester.”

Vince considered trying to stop her, then thought better of it. He wasn’t exactly experienced at relationships, but he knew enough to not try and deprive his girlfriend of something she would view as ample fun. Besides, no one was going to force him to drink. He could go and just enjoy the company.

“Rock on!” Nick said, sidling up to him. “Okay, Vince, this is it. This river trip, I am seeing you finally unwind. You, good sir, will try drinking. No arguments, because every time you open your mouth to say no I’m just cramming a shot down it.”

Vince supposed a couple would be okay. It was a new experience and all. Besides, they’d be out in nature, along with heaven only knew how many other college kids on spring break. It might be nice to blend in for a bit and get away from all the Lander uniqueness.

“I heard about this thing,” Gilbert said, adding his own name to the list. “Don’t they have a deal with some landowner so we’re the only ones on that river? No worrying about anyone seeing us use our powers.”

Vince was... well, Vince was pretty much just thinking “Damn it” over and over and over.

“All right, class, get inside,” Dean Blaine said from within the room. “The sheet will be there for at least a week. I assure you, a chance will be had by all to sign up.”

There was some grumbling, but they all piled in and took their seats.

“Settle down, class,” Dean Blaine told them. “I know you’re all excited about this weekend, but try to keep it under control. It’s only Tuesday after all.”

There were several exchanged glances of curiosity, followed by a multitude of shrugs admitting ignorance.

Julia raised her hand.

“Yes, Ms. Shaw?”

“What’s this weekend?”

“Tsk tsk, Ms. Shaw. I would have expected you to pay at least some attention to the Lander event calendar. Would anyone care to inform Ms. Shaw of what she has forgotten?”

He was met by vacant eyes and silence. The few in the class who did know the weekend’s significance didn’t dare proclaim it for fear of being judged as looking forward to it. Which they, in truth, were.

“I must say, I’m disappointed. Over thirty of you here and not one person knows what this weekend is? It’s Parents’ Weekend. I’d have thought you’d all have it marked on your calendars,” Dean Blaine, barely hiding a

chuckle. He was significantly older than his students, but not so old that he'd forgotten the stomach-tightening terror of knowing your parents would be visiting you at college.

"Wait... you mean our parents..." Stella said, slowly circling the answer she didn't want to hear.

"Your parents were all sent invitations inviting them to a weekend of fun and mingling here at Lander. They'll be allowed to tour the facility, join in some parent and child social events, or just wander the campus meeting your friends and professors," Dean Blaine explained.

"And these invitations, these are already sent out?" Rich asked from the front row.

"Indeed. Ever since one year when a student attempted to hijack the mail truck we've made it policy to only remind the students of Parents' Weekend after all invitations are delivered," Dean Blaine, glossing over the whole of the story. In truth, it had been several students who'd gone after the mail truck, but his class didn't need to know that any more than they needed to know how Dean Blaine had such extensive, one could even say firsthand, knowledge of the event.

"Um... what time will they be arriving?" Will asked.

"Friday afternoon. On that note, you should know that gym will start an hour early, during what would usually be your study period. We want you to have extra time so you can all be cleaned up and ready when your parents arrive."

Some of the students looked sullen, a few looked eager, and most looked downright terrified. It gave Dean Blaine a small sense of comfort knowing that no matter how powerful a child might be, they could still fear the embarrassment of their parents. Then he noticed a few faces in the crowd that looked nothing like the others. These were the faces of a few who were trying very hard not to look as sad as they felt. Dean Blaine's amusement swiftly passed.

"Enough of that," he said. "It's time to start class."

## 89.

"I'm afraid I just don't agree," Mr. Numbers said politely, taking a sip of tea to punctuate his sentence.

"I'm not asking for agreement, merely assistance, even if only by association," Mr. Transport replied.

The two men were taking advantage of the time their charges were occupied in gym to pop out and get lunch at the only place one could find truly delicious Italian food.

"I'll concede that your idea does regain us some of the ground we were forced to sacrifice for the mountain trial; however, I feel it comes off as far too transparent an attempt to do just that," Mr. Numbers said. "If we are seen as actively manipulating their emotions then it would undermine our efforts, not aid them."

"That argument is only valid if they see it as an act done for the sake of manipulation. If they take it as genuine then it would do wonders to foster some trust. Trust that would greatly assist us down the line," Mr. Transport countered.

"I think the risk is too great against the potential reward," Mr. Numbers assessed bluntly. "The optimum gain is simply too minimal to justify such an overt gesture."

Mr. Transport slowly cut into his manicotti, considering Mr. Numbers' point. It was true that this could work against them; however, it was also true that Mr. Transport still wanted to proceed with the plan. Not just for the reasons he'd advocated to Mr. Numbers, but because it was an act of decency he wanted to perform. Mr. Numbers wouldn't accept sentiment in place of logic, though. Mr. Transport thought carefully, then voiced an idea.

"We could get some of them to assist us."

Mr. Numbers merely raised an eyebrow rather than conjure the effort of a vocal reaction.

"It's not without precedent in circumstances such as these. We would need Nick and Mary. The others trust Mary thanks to her ability, and Nick has been shaping their perceptions since the first day. If they agree to aid us then we significantly reduce risk," Mr. Transport said.

"Valid," Mr. Numbers said. "However, working with Nick in itself

generates a risk.”

“Then let’s begin with Mary. Broach the topic with her over your next chess game. You can gauge her reaction and decide then if the equation is more adequately balanced.”

“Very well,” Mr. Numbers agreed. “Assuming the risk reward ratio becomes justifiable, I will agree to help you with your project.”

“Thank you,” Mr. Transport said.

“Not at all,” Mr. Numbers replied. “Shall we get dessert?”

“Sounds delicious. I believe there is an excellent bakery down the street,” Mr. Transport suggested.

“Perfect,” Mr. Numbers agreed. “One thing I love about New York, variety is always close at hand.”

\* \* \*

“Because I’m retired, that’s why!” Dean Blaine yelled into the phone. He was in his office and had been attempting to unwind from the day. His attempt was clearly unsuccessful, as his face was flushed and a small vein near his eye was beginning to throb. Dean Blaine prided himself on his unflappable demeanor in dealing with the students; however, the person currently on the line was not enrolled at Lander. Aside from that, there were just some things that got under his skin.

There was a murmur of words from the phone.

“Save the guilt trip. I’ve told you people more times than I care to count that I’m done. There are plenty of capable, active Heroes out there who can fix your problem. I know that because I trained them. That’s what I do now, since you seem to have forgotten.”

Another murmur crackled across the lines.

“Well, if time is such an issue then quit wasting time with me and find someone who’s willing to help. Good day!”

Dean Blaine slammed the receiver down, cracking off a small piece of plastic in the process. He took several deep breaths and got up from his desk. It took him a few moments of rooting through one of the drawers in his file cabinet, but he finally emerged with a small white bottle. He poured of glass of water, then deposited two tablets from the bottle into the glass and watched as they fizzed enthusiastically. Only after downing the bubbly liquid in a

single gulp did he retake his seat.

Dean Blaine knew he should take it as compliment. He'd been retired for nearly a decade and yet they still called him when things went too far south too fast. No one wanted to accept that he'd retired, even after all this time. Not too shabby for a guy who had barely made it into the HCP to begin with. He had to believe some of the reluctance to let him go was hype, though. After all, he was one of the few graduates still left from his graduating class. The Class of Legends, people had called it.

Globe may have been at the top, but all ten Heroes who came from that class went on to become famous worldwide. Though, admittedly, some gained fame from less than ideal circumstances.

He mentally ticked through the class roster. Globe and Intra were dead, of course. Wisp was in prison. Shimmerpath was missing. Bull-Rush had retired and was now in the private sector. Raze was considered wanted and dangerous. His mental accounting stalled on Raze. They had been roommates nearly their whole time at Lander. They sparred often, honing their skills against a fellow well-trained opponent. No one had been more surprised than he when word spread about Raze's crimes.

Dean Blaine rose from his chair once again, this time heading for the door. He would go watch the juniors' class; it would be going on around now. Seeing the students always centered him. It reminded him of his own days at Lander. Years spent fighting, competing, and bonding with fellow Supers. Of a time when he lived and trained with his best friends. Sometimes, when he was watching the young ones work toward their goal, he could almost forget what had happened to the rest of his class, could lose himself in that ignorant memory of decades ago. Only almost, though. Wherever his mind let him wander, reality always just a step behind waiting to pounce.



## 90.

"I think you'll like my parents," Sasha said as she and Vince sat on her couch and flipped through the meager offering of television. "They're pretty chill people on the whole. I was thinking we could all do dinner one night."

"That seems nice," Vince said evenly. He'd never actually had a girlfriend before, so meeting the parents was going to be a new experience for him. One that he hadn't heard the nicest things about.

"Yup. So what else are you going to do with your down time? I don't want you to be lonely if everyone is occupied with their parents," Sasha said.

"Nothing to worry about," Vince told her. "Alice and Nick both have single parents that work all the time, so apparently they aren't coming. Hershel's mom is going to be here, though, and so are both of Mary's parents. So worst case scenario I'll be part of a trio for the weekend."

"Long as you save Saturday night for me," Sasha said with a smile. "My parents will love you."

"You think so?"

"Sure, what's not to love? You're a Super with an awesome ability, you're smart, you're kind, and pretty darn cute if I do say so," Sasha said.

"That's very sweet," Vince said, squirming a little at his own lack of understanding of how to take so many compliments. Instead he opted to change the subject. "So your parents wanted you with a Super, I guess?"

"Like you wouldn't believe. They're convinced that two Supers are more likely to pop out Super grandbabies," Sasha said. "Which is great, for when I'm, like, thirty. But I mean, come on, what teenage girl wants to hear her mom rag on the guy she took to the prom for being an inferior genetic supplier?"

"That does seem a bit odd," Vince agreed.

"They mellowed out after senior year, though," Sasha continued, a devilish grin on her face. "I got them to back off by showing them how much worse it could be."

"What'd you do?"

"I let a Powered guy take me out one night. All of sudden the normal boys didn't seem so bad," Sasha chuckled. "Since then they've been way

cooler about it all. Sort of a moot point, though, because I wound up with a Super boyfriend anyway.”

“Heh, yeah, you did,” Vince said. He squirmed again, but this time for a very different uncomfortable reason.

\* \* \*

“Good evening, Alice, have I disturbed your studies?”

“No, everything is fine,” Alice replied, moving the recently picked up phone to her right ear. She was sitting at her desk working through some notes when her father’s ringtone had blared out.

“Excellent to hear. I was calling to inform you that my plane will be arriving Friday afternoon. I will be in town until Saturday mid-morning,” Charles Adair told her.

“Wait, you’re actually coming in this weekend?”

“Was I unclear? Yes, I will be there for a little under a day. I’ve already gotten my hotel set up for the stay, but I would like to invite you to dinner during my time there. I could pick you up at six.”

“Oh... yeah. That sounds great. I’ll see you Friday at six.”

“Excellent. Dress appropriately. Good night, dear.”

“Night, Daddy.”

Alice set down the phone, trying to suppress the surprise welling up inside of her. Her dad was actually going to fly in specifically to see her for Parents’ Weekend. That was downright flabbergasting.

She glanced over at her poor, already stuffed to its breaking point, closet. When he said to dress appropriately, it meant he was having dinner somewhere extremely high class. This might just call for a whole new outfit.

She shoved aside her notes and fired up her computer. She needed to see what times the local stores were open until tomorrow.

\* \* \*

“I need a favor,” Mary said, plopping down next to Nick on the common room sofa.

“Wow, you really don’t pussy-foot around, do you?” Nick replied, setting down the book he’d been reading.

“Would it do any good?” Mary asked.

“Not even a little. So what do you need?”

“Alice is going to ask me to go shopping with her tomorrow after class. I’m leading a study group that evening, so I can’t,” Mary explained.

“Wait, back up a second. Did I miss the part where your power lets you see the future?”

“No, you missed the part where the girl in the room next to me let out a very sharp mental squeal of joy because she found out her father is coming to visit. She started browsing around for stores to buy a dinner outfit at, and then decided she’d prefer to have someone to talk with while she shops,” Mary said.

“Okay, see, I think I know where this is going, and I have to tell you I am really leaning toward no,” Nick said. “In fact, it’s less of a lean than it is me standing directly on top of no. Like, it’s under my feet, the no. I’m saying no, if you didn’t get that.”

“Please, Nick. I think it’ll be good for her to have someone to share an excited day with.”

“Uh huh, and I’m the natural second choice after you?” Nick asked.

“Well, no, not really. I think I can talk her into it, though,” Mary replied.

“Why me?”

“Because you two are actually pretty similar. Besides, you know more about modern fashion trends than any other guy in this house,” Mary said.

“Damn, you are just awful at this,” Nick told her.

“That’s why I try to avoid doing it. I can’t come up with a better solution, unfortunately. Trust me, I tried.”

Nick thought it over for a moment, turning the situation around in his head. Mary was coming to him with a genuine need. That wasn’t a situation he should outright dismiss.

“I don’t do favors,” Nick said. “I do, however, do deals. So you want me to say yes when you convince Alice to ask me to go shopping with her? Then I want a day.”

“A day?”

“Yes. One twenty four hour period in which you promise to stay the hell out of my thoughts. No peeking, no listening, no popping in. On your honor. One day,” Nick said.

“Agreed,” Mary said with some slight hesitation.

“Then consider it done,” Nick said. “Assuming you really can talk her into asking me, of course.”

## 91.

“Pale pink, or off pink?” Alice asked, holding up yet another pair of nearly identical shoes.

“That depends. When you say your father is coming to town, is that slang for your daddy, or your handler as some girls call them?”

“You’re inferring these shoes will make me look like a hooker,” Alice replied.

“And they say the blonde ones are all looks,” Nick said with an unfazed grin. He wasn’t sure how Mary had talked her into it (for that matter, neither was Alice), but Alice had been convinced that Nick would be an acceptable shopping substitute. So instead of spending his evening relaxing and planning for the weekend, Nick was stuck on shopping duty. In truth, he’d been down this road many times with many girls, but he found that if they knew you didn’t mind then they felt encouraged to bring you along more often. That much, at least, he wanted to avoid.

“I know they aren’t perfectly high class, but I thought with the dress I picked out it wouldn’t be pushing the envelope too much,” Alice said, defending her selection.

“You thought wrong. If we were going out to a bar or with our friends I would say no problem. If we’re talking people with actual fashion then I think we both know you’ve gone over the line of class,” Nick said.

Alice sighed. “Damn it, you’re right. I hate you for being right.”

“Long as we’re hating me for appropriate reasons, I think I can cope,” Nick said.

“You know this means I have to keep looking, though,” Alice warned him.

Nick spread out his hands. “I’ve got all night, Princess. Nobody for me to impress tomorrow, so the room can stay messy and the clothes piled up.” In truth, Nick was only as messy as he needed to be in his Melbrook room. He preferred a meticulously tidy living space; however, such things would draw too much attention in a college freshman, especially when he had roommates keen on stopping by.

“Oh yeah, you, Vince, and I were supposed to be the parentless Lonely Hearts Club this weekend,” Alice said. “Sorry I kind of bailed on that.”

“You had family come in. If that was a viable option for either of us we’d easily do the same,” Nick assured her. “We’ll just have to find a way to soldier on without you.”

“Uh huh. Don’t do anything too mean to Vince,” Alice cautioned him.

“Perish the thought. I was planning on driving him out to have a nice relaxing dinner off campus, away from the hustle and bustle of those with visiting parents,” Nick told her.

Alice raised an eyebrow.

“...at a strip club,” Nick finished with a smirk.

“I’m pretty sure Sasha would punch you if she found out you tricked Vince into going to a strip club. Not like I punch, either. She’d aim right for the dick.”

Nick winced visibly. “I hadn’t thought of that part. I don’t know why she’d react that way, though, it’s not like she has anything to worry about. I mean, have you ever known a guy less likely to cheat, on anyone or at anything, than Vince?”

“True, but feelings aren’t always so logical,” Alice said. “Sometimes people overreact when the person they care about is ogling tramps.”

“I prefer to think of them less as tramps and more as ambitious young ladies paying their way through nursing school,” Nick said.

“The nearest nursing school is fifty miles from here,” Alice pointed out.

“So they commute. All the more reason to work extra hard for the gas money.”

Alice briefly considered throwing a shoe at him. She stopped herself, though, realizing that wouldn’t send the right kind of message. She needed to be calm and rational in her approach to chastising Nick for this type of behavior.

So she threw all four shoes instead. It was immensely satisfying.

\* \* \*

Mr. Transport stepped through the front door and into the small hallway of the Melbrook foyer. He usually teleported back to his and Mr. Numbers’ apartment; however, from time to time it made sense to do an in-person walk-through. It was a gentle reminder to the students that though they

may not be visible, there were authority figures on hand at any given time. Given that it was Thursday night, which was practically a Friday for all college-based purposes, he expected to walk into the common room and find all the students hatching some sort of night-occupying scheme.

What greeted his eyes as he passed from the hallway was significantly less jubilant. Only Vince was here, reading some chemistry on the couch.

“Good evening, Vince,” Mr. Transport greeted.

“Hi, Mr. Transport,” Vince said, looking up with a smile. “How’s your night going?”

“Very well. And yours?”

“Not bad. Just a few problems left and I’m done for the night.”

“Commendable. Vince, I can’t help but wonder where the others are tonight. Some sort of mischief I should be concerned of?” Mr. Transport asked.

Vince laughed. “Nah, nothing that I know of, sir. Everyone is kind of gearing up for Parents’ Weekend. Hershel and Mary are both in their rooms cleaning, and Nick went with Alice to shop for some new outfit. Turns out her dad is coming in and they’re going somewhere nice.”

“That seems enjoyable,” Mr. Transport said, carefully gliding over anything that could be construed as a question as to why Vince’s activities weren’t in the same vein. Mr. Transport was already quite informed on that answer and tactful enough not to bring it up.

“I hope so,” Vince replied. “I don’t get the feeling Alice sees a whole lot of her dad. She’s trying to downplay it, but she seems excited.”

“I’m sure it will be fine,” Mr. Transport assured him. At the mention of Nick, Mr. Transport recalled that he didn’t possess any family likely to visit either. “I assume you and Nick will be up to some merrymaking of your own tomorrow night?”

“He mentioned something about dinner off campus, which seemed like a nice change-up,” Vince said. “Say what you want about Nick, he knows how to have fun.”

“That he does,” Mr. Transport said, feeling a bit relieved. He’d grown a bit fond of Vince and didn’t like the idea of the boy stuck alone, surrounded by people with loving families. “Well, I’ll leave you to your studies. Have a good night, Vince.”

“You, too, Mr. Transport. See you tomorrow when we go to class.”

Mr. Transport walked through the common room and into the kitchen. Once there he made the quick teleportation into the apartment tucked away behind the steel door by the stove.

“You’re late,” Mr. Numbers chastised him. “You know we have some reports to make tomorrow.”

“I stopped to talk with a student,” Mr. Transport said defensively.

“That’s less of an excuse than you might believe it to be and more of an explanation on how you wasted the time that made you late,” Mr. Numbers snapped. He was often on edge before reports were due which, given the possible circumstances of a bad one, was not an inexcusable crime.

“I’ll remind you of that next time Mary challenges you to a game of chess,” Mr. Transport said, joining him at the table where papers were already spread out.

“The chess is different,” Mr. Numbers replied. “That is education.”

“I’m sure,” Mr. Transport said. “Shall we debate this more or simply acknowledge that I’m here and it’s time to get to work?”

“Work,” Mr. Numbers said sharply.

“Then work it is,” Mr. Transport agreed, concealing something of a grin behind a fit of fake coughing.



## 92.

“Hershel!” yelled an enthusiastic middle-aged voice.

“Hi, Mom,” Hershel said, embarrassment welling up as his mother gave him a tremendous embrace.

The Melbrook students were gathered in the common room, relaxing after gym on Friday. In honor of the weekend’s occasion, the dorm’s front steel door had been deactivated, allowing visitors to enter as they pleased. It was a nice way around reminding the parents that their children had been experimented on and were still under careful watch. Plus, it saved anyone from having to get up to welcome people.

Hershel’s mother had been the first to arrive, so the remainder of the students got up from their chairs to greet her. All of them were there, though Nick and Vince were present purely to meet the makers of their dorm mates.

“These must be your friends I’ve heard so much about,” Mrs. Daniels said after she had thoroughly squeezed Hershel. “I feel like I know them already. The one with the silver hair must be Vince.”

“Nice to meet you, Mrs. Daniels,” Vince said.

“Good to meet you, too. And I see the other boy is wearing sunglasses indoors and curiously well-dressed, so that would be Nick.”

“Bingo,” Nick affirmed. He’d gussied himself up a bit in honor of the night to come. He liked to make the right kind of impression on the ladies of the evening.

“Which leaves these two lovely young ladies as Mary and Alice,” Mrs. Daniels concluded.

“Correct,” Alice said. “I’m Alice and this is Mary. It’s a pleasure to meet you, Mrs. Daniels, we greatly enjoy our friendship with Hershel.”

“Ditto,” Mary agreed, somewhat shyly.

“Well, you are such a polite bunch,” Mrs. Daniels said. “I’m glad to see Hershel has made such nice friends.” She turned back to her son. “All right, let’s go see your room and then we can go out to dinner.”

“Sounds great,” Hershel said, relieved his mother didn’t want to dally too much with the others. He loved his mother very dearly, but there were certain times in a boy’s life when a maternal presence is one of pure,

unbridled embarrassment. Being around a girl you're trying to work up the nerve to ask out was definitely one of those times.

Hershel took his mother by the hand and walked her into the boys' lounge, the steel door whooshing shut behind them.

"She seemed pleasant," Vince observed once they had gone.

"Yeah. Makes you wonder what kind of nutjob the dad must be to have produced a kid like Roy," Nick added.

Nick felt something kick him sharply in the shin. He glanced down, immediately suspecting Alice, only to see nothing there. On a hunch he glanced over at Mary. The look in her eyes left no room to wonder about the nature of his invisible assailant.

Before he had a chance to react, though, Mary's focus shifted abruptly.

"Ooh! My parents are here," she cried. "I'm heading out to meet them. See you guys later!"

"Wait, we don't get to meet the folks that spawned our local wacky telepath? I feel gypped," Nick complained.

"It's nothing personal; they're just normal people and they're not used to being around Supers," Mary said, making her way to the door. "I need to get them a little adjusted first. I promise I'll bring them around once they can better handle themselves." With that, she was out the door like a shot.

"I still sort of feel like we just got brushed off," Vince said.

"Either we did or they did, and I'm not about to go rooting around the psyche of a telepath trying to figure it out," Nick replied.

"Amen to that," Alice agreed.

There were no new arrivals immediately following Mary's departure, so the other three returned to lounging about. Well, Nick and Vince lounged. Alice sat carefully so as not to wrinkle or upset the outfit she had purchased. The effort was understandable; after all, the girl looked sleek. Her black dress was complimented by a mere whisper of pink trim, along with matching shoes and a handbag. She'd spent more time than she would ever admit on getting her makeup just right, which essentially meant making it look like she wasn't wearing any. Her long, platinum blonde hair was pulled up and styled, with a few key strands hanging down for effect. In short, she was the picture of adolescent elegance, just as she had been taught to be for many, many years.

“I got to go take a wiz,” Nick announced, hurling himself up from the chair.

“You are so amazingly crude,” Alice sighed.

“That wasn’t crude. Crude would be saying I need to go defile the porcelain,” Nick countered.

“Touché?” Alice said, not quite certain whether it was a win for Nick or a loss for everyone in the room. Nick didn’t stick around to find out; he headed over to the boys’ side and swept through the door.

The next man to walk into the room was not a returning Nick with an empty bladder. It was instead a gentleman dressed simply yet spectacularly. He wore black slacks, a white shirt open at the throat, and a black jacket. A simple pair of cufflinks and a watch were all the accessory added on to his ensemble. It was a classic look, yet not an impressive one. Unless, of course, one was aware of how much each piece of the outfit cost. At that point, he was a picture of splendor and decadence.

“Good evening,” said the tall, suited man.

“Hi, Daddy!” Alice said, extracting herself carefully from her chair. It was a difficult task, not only because of the dress but because of the wave of excitement that crashed against her. She and her father didn’t see each other all that often, and this was the first time she could ever remember him making a trip specifically to spend time with her.

“Hi, Mr. Adair,” Vince said, pulling himself to his feet and sticking out his hand. “I’m Vince Reynolds.”

“A pleasure to meet you, Vince,” he said, pumping the hand once and immediately releasing it. “I would love to stay and get to know you better, but unfortunately Alice and I are shorter on time than I’d intended.”

“Oh, no problem,” Vince said. “You guys have fun tonight.”

“Erm... we’ll certainly try. Alice, are you ready?”

“Ready,” Alice chimed off brightly.

“Then let us make some haste,” he said, flashing Vince a million dollar smile. It seemed just a touch familiar to Vince, but it quickly slipped out of his mind.

Just like that, Vince was the only one left in the room. He sat back down and waited for Nick to finish his business so they could go eat. It was

only a few seconds of waiting when Nick stepped back in from the boys' side.

“What’d I miss?”

“Alice’s dad,” Vince told him.

“Damn, I was looking forward to that one,” Nick lied. “Oh well, what’s done is done. Food?”

“Sounds great,” Vince agreed. He hopped to his feet and turned toward the door, just in time to see an unfamiliar man step through it. The man was dressed casually in jeans and a shirt. He was fit without being intimidating, and average looking in nearly every facet. Vince started to ask the man his business here when Nick’s voice from behind cut him off. It was filled with something odd in Nick’s tone, something Vince wasn’t certain he’d ever heard there before. It was thick with surprise.

“Gerry?”

## 93.

“Wow, you got a big car just to be here for a day,” Alice noted as she walked outside and saw the white stretch limousine.

“A necessary evil, unfortunately,” her father said.

“I’m confused, though; I thought you hated stretch limos. You said they were tacky, for people who wanted to look impressive but didn’t know how,” Alice said.

“And that belief still holds firmly true,” her father replied. “Though I’ll thank you not to mention it around our guests tonight. The limo was to appeal to their tastes rather than my own.”

“What guests? I thought you flew in to see me,” Alice said, slowing down her trot to the car.

“No, dear, I said I was going to be in town and invited you to dinner. I’m here to close a deal with Horatio Vinders for one of his offshoot companies. He insisted on coming into town this weekend to visit his daughter Beth, so I offered to take them out to dinner,” he explained, his gait never even considering an idea as indignant as slowing down.

Alice scrambled to catch up. She wasn’t sure how she was feeling right now, though she was certain it wasn’t pleasant. All the same, she didn’t want to be left behind entirely.

“Mr. Adair,” called a young girl somewhat older than Alice. She had stepped out from the behind the limo, clearly waiting for them. She had her hair trimmed short and wore a midnight blue dress paired with a few adornments of tasteful jewelry. She looked familiar, and Alice realized she had seen this girl many times before wandering the halls beneath the school. At that time she’d been wearing a grey uniform, so that made her either a sophomore or a junior. Alice’s guess was junior.

“Beth,” Charles Adair said, leaning in and giving the girl a respectful kiss on the cheek. “You grow more beautiful every time I see you. Is your father already inside?”

“Oh no, I’m so sorry but he was caught up momentarily speaking with one of my professors. It was so embarrassing, she wouldn’t stop going on and on about how wonderful a student I am. Father sent me ahead to let you know of his delay and tell you that we certainly don’t expect you to wait. You two go ahead to dinner and we’ll catch up later.”

Alice felt a bubble of joy rising in her; at least she would have a little time to talk with her dad, just the two of them. It wasn't what she had expected, but it was something.

"Nonsense," Charles Adair said, waving her off. "I wouldn't hear of such a thing, leaving you two to find your own way when I have this enormous vehicle just idling by. Don't even mention it again; Alice and I will wait right here with you until your father arrives."

"Mr. Adair, you are so kind," Beth replied. "And it was Alice, wasn't it? I think I've seen you around, it's a pleasure to meet you."

"The pleasure is all mine," Alice said automatically. She'd been through so many formal greetings it came like second nature to her now.

"Beth's father tells me she's quite accomplished here at Lander," Mr. Adair interjected. "A third year in the same program as yourself, Alice. You would do well to listen to any bits of wisdom she might pass down."

Alice choked herself back from snapping that she already knew what year Beth was just from paying attention below ground. Instead she lowered her eyes and said, "I am always grateful for the guidance of my seniors."

"Such an excellent attitude to have here at Lander," Beth said, flashing a toothy grin. "You'll find yourself going far here with such humility."

Alice said nothing. She'd managed to forget what this was like, the subtle barbs, the plays for power, the dance of the wealthy debutantes. For that's what this was. Beth was from society, too. Her father had less wealth than Alice's, but since Mr. Adair was trying to impress them, it was simple enough for Beth to establish herself as the alpha between the two. It was a tactful duel of concealed attacks and hasty retreats, an art Alice had learned long ago. And now, standing here in the crisp air of a dying winter, she realized how much she loathed it to her very core.

\* \* \*

"You look good, Campbell, they already got you whipped back into shape after your month off over Christmas," Gerry said, stepping the rest of the way into the common room.

"Thanks. So, what brings you to Lander?" Nick asked.

"Well, Ms. Pips couldn't be here herself, of course, you know how busy things get on the weekends, but she thought you might like at least one familiar face on Parents' Weekend," Gerry explained.

“That is... surprising,” Nick said. He took a moment to recover himself, then turned to Vince. “This is Gerry. He works for Ms. Pips. He was my tutor growing up.”

“Nice to meet you, sir,” Vince said politely, shaking his hand.

“You too, kid, and that is some grip,” Gerry replied. “They making all you kids into ultra-soldiers?”

“Just basic Hero training,” Vince said, an unwitting smile coming to his lips.

“Yeah, well, with training like what they’re giving you, I’m glad I’m not a criminal. Four years of this and you’ll be able to take on an army,” Gerry quipped.

“Maybe, but we’ll all hope we never have to,” Vince said.

“Damn right, kid. So Nick, you know any good burger joints around here?”

“A couple,” Nick replied. “But Gerry, Vince and I sort of made plans already.”

“Well then, Vince can come along,” Gerry said with a big grin.

Vince took a step back and raised his hands. “No, no, I really couldn’t. You two go enjoy yourselves. I’ll call Alex up; his parents aren’t coming in ‘til tomorrow so we can still have unsupervised fun.”

“You sure, kid? We got plenty of room in my car,” Gerry said.

“Really, Vince, you’re more than welcome,” Nick reiterated.

“Wouldn’t dream of it,” Vince said. “You guys have fun, I’ll see you when you get back.”

“Okay, if you’re sure,” Nick said hesitantly. Vince nodded emphatically.

“I guess that’s that, then. Good to meet you, Vince,” Gerry said, stepping over to the door. He and Nick walked wordlessly up the hallway. Only after they had stepped outside, checked to make sure the door was secure, and done a visual sweep did any words pass their lips.

“Good kid,” Gerry commented. “He the one without any family?”

“Yup,” Nick confirmed.

“You know he was lying about the other friend, right? He’s going to sit in there alone all night.”

“I know, Gerry. We invited him, though.”

“We could have pushed harder.”

Nick shook his head. “Wouldn’t have done any good. I slipped up and let him see how glad I was to see you. Vince could have never infringed on our time after something like that. He wouldn’t have budged no matter how hard we pushed.”

“Huh. Quite a guy you befriended there.”

“Whatever you say. Ready to get some food?” Nick asked.

“Sure, my car is over that way,” Gerry said, pointing past a garish stretch limousine and a few people dressed to the nines standing around it.

“Crap,” Nick said. “Let’s circle around. The blonde wearing black is another dorm mate of mine and I’d really rather not get drawn into talking with her or her dad.”

Gerry let out a low whistle. “She’s quite a looker. Which one is that, the flyer or the telepath?”

“Flyer,” Nick replied.

“Alice, then. And the guy with her is her dad. Any idea who the other girl is?”

“Not a clue about her name, but she’s one of the few female juniors in the HCP,” Nick replied. He had long ago compiled a mental list of every face he saw below ground as well as what class they belonged in.

“She must be some kind of powerful bitch,” Gerry observed. “Your friend looks pretty uncomfortable.”

“She’s fine,” Nick said, brushing it off. “Let’s go eat.”

“Campbell, if you think she’s fine, we need to go back over how to read body language and I mean now.”

“Fine, so she’s miserable and trying to hide it,” Nick replied. “That’s her problem; I’m off duty on the friend act.”

“Isn’t this the girl who saved your life?” Gerry asked.

“Yeah, on the mountain. Why?”



“Heavens above, kid, what do you mean why? The girl you owe your life to is practically biting back tears and you want to sneak by so she can’t see you.”

Nick sighed. “You know, for a con man, you sure have strict moral code.”

“The key part of con man is the word ‘man.’ You have to have empathy with your fellow human beings or you’re just a sociopath, and they make the shittiest con men alive,” Gerry pointed out.

“So what do you want me to do? Go slash the tires of the car so they can’t go to dinner?”

“Interject yourself, give her someone familiar she can lean on in the middle of shitty situation,” Gerry said.

“How? I wouldn’t do that. I mean... the me that they know wouldn’t do that. Hell, he wouldn’t even know how,” Nick said.

Gerry shrugged. “You got your license to work solo a long time ago. It’s not my job to figure out the angle for you.”

“No, it’s your job to tell me when to break my cover for no good reason,” Nick snapped back.

“Campbell, right now you’d be dead in the ground if not for that girl. There’s your good reason. If you can’t see how you owe her at least a little help when she’s upset, then maybe basic human empathy is something you’ve already lost touch with,” Gerry said simply.

“Damn it,” Nick cursed, taking off his sunglasses and handing them to Gerry. “Give me those back tonight. Lunchie and Munchie’s Burgers on 22 and V. One in the morning. And you are so buying after this shit.”

“Deal,” Gerry agreed as he watched Nick stride off across the grass.

\* \* \*

“-so that’s why I’m holding myself in seventh place,” Beth said, concluding her story. “I could go higher, but right now I just feel like those other six need the self-esteem from it more. I mean, I’m already so blessed, why be greedy?”

“A very kind gesture,” Mr. Adair said. “You’re quite the caring girl.”

“Indeed,” Alice agreed. She wasn’t gritting her teeth yet, but it was becoming an effort. It was strange; she’d been the good little daughter for so

long without even trying. Yet after only a few months at Lander, living in this role felt like getting dental surgery without anesthetic. She didn't know what could have changed so much in such a short time. Had Alice been a touch more introspective, it might have occurred to her that the answer was herself. Perhaps she would have arrived there anyway, but at that particular moment a considerable interruption to her thought process occurred.

Alice felt an arm curl gently around the small of her back. At the same time a hand cradled her chin and pulled it in close. A pair of lips landed lightly on her cheek before she was released from the silken net of the grip that held her. She turned her head and found herself looking into a pair of brown, utterly foreign eyes. She was surprised, though not nearly as shocked as when she pulled back her gaze and saw the face that owned those eyes.

"Sorry I'm late, darling," Nick said, giving her a comforting smile. "I got caught up at the study session for physics." Nick turned away from the stunned-into-silence Alice and faced her father.

"You must be Mr. Adair. I must say it's an honor to finally meet you, sir. I'm Nicholas Campbell, Alice's boyfriend."

## 94.

“A pleasure,” Mr. Adair said, his eyebrows lifting. “Forgive my surprise, my daughter never mentioned that she had a suitor.”

“Yes, we only recently decided to make things official, so there hasn’t been much time to tell anyone,” Nick said. “It took me quite a bit of work to show your daughter I was worth having.”

“Good to hear. A man who won’t put in the work is a man who won’t stick around when things get hard,” Mr. Adair said.

“I couldn’t agree more, sir.”

It was at this point that Alice’s brain finally snapped back from the certainty that she was having a truly awful nightmare and sprang into action. After it entertained a few violent, murderous scenarios for how to deal with Nick, it decided to focus on more plausible solution instead.

“Honey,” Alice said in a voice dripping with sweetness. “Can I speak with you for a minute?”

“Only if your father and his guest will excuse us,” Nick said deferentially.

“By all means,” Mr. Adair said.

“Um, sure,” Beth chimed in.

“So kind of you both,” Nick said. He took Alice’s arm in his and walked away from the car. When they were about forty feet away Alice turned to him with a huge smile on her face. From a distance it was good camouflage, but if you were too close the murder in her eyes gave away its falsehood.

“Any last words to your testicles before I separate them from your body?”

“Only together for a few minutes and already you know I love the kinky stuff,” Nick replied.

“Nick, what the fuck do you think you’re doing?”

“Helping, believe it or not. You looked so helpless dealing with that bitch that I decided to jump in and help.”

“I wasn’t helpless.”

“Fine, miserable then.”

That one Alice had a harder time disputing, so instead she went after Nick’s methods.

“So how exactly does you being my boyfriend help?”

“I can be charming when I want to be. Besides, I thought it might just be nice to have a friend along. I mean, you’ve been looking forward to your dad coming since you found out. From the size of the car and the way that girl is dressed, I’m guessing it isn’t the family affair you were expecting. I just figured if I were in your shoes I’d rather have a friend than face such a disappointment alone,” Nick explained.

“That’s... surprisingly sweet-intentioned,” Alice said. “You’re not secretly the shape-shifting kid, are you?”

“Would the shape-shifting kid know you used to have a very well-justified fear of heights?” Nick asked.

“Touché,” Alice said. “I still don’t know how comfortable I am with you pretending to be my boyfriend, though.”

“Look, I’ve already made the play and you went with it. So now we’re either together, or you get to explain how your friend took pity on you and pretended to be your beau to your father and that oh-so-lovely young woman.”

“Damn it. You’ve got a point.”

“Hence why I made it. Anyway, you got anything else? We need to wrap this up and walk back before it seems like we’re up to something,” Nick pointed out.

“There is one little flaw in your plan. We’re going to a business dinner, and you weren’t invited. I appreciate the sentiment, but you won’t be able to tag along once Beth’s dad gets here.”

Nick threw back his head and let out a genuine laugh. “That’s nothing to worry about.”

“Why not?”

“Trust me, I’ll be there at your father’s insistence. Just wait and see.”

“Okay, wow me, jerk,” Alice said with a more sincere smile. “Oh, and one more thing. I like the way you look without your sunglasses.”

“Don’t get used to it,” Nick replied. “But thanks.”

\* \* \*

“Where is everyone?” Mr. Transport asked as he stepped into the living room and once again found Vince sitting by himself.

“Out with parents, or parental figures,” Vince said, mindlessly surfing through channels on the television.

“Ah. I surmise Nick received a surprise visitor?”

“Yeah, a tutor that he’s apparently pretty close to,” Vince replied. “He was really happy to see him, so they went to spend some time together.”

“You didn’t tag along?” Mr. Transport asked.

“Nah. It’s family, and I got the feeling Nick didn’t get to see him much. I wouldn’t have felt right intruding.”

“Very respectable. What will you do instead?”

“Nothing too exciting. I think I’ll go grab dinner at the cafeteria and catch up on some homework,” Vince said, standing from the couch and turning off the television.

“I see,” Mr. Transport said. Those were productive, responsible activities. They were an excellent way to deal with loneliness or boredom. He should retreat now and leave Vince to his plans. He shouldn’t get too involved, after all.

“Vince, your comment about eating off campus got me thinking about how long it’s been since I dined out myself. I’ve got a craving for a delicious sandwich shop I know. Would you care to join me?” Mr. Transport asked.

Vince looked wary. “That’s okay, Mr. Transport. Campus food is fine.”

Of course the boy wouldn’t want to accept pity. Mr. Transport tried to adjust his thinking; what would Mr. Numbers do in this situation? He wasn’t entirely sure what the answer was, but the thought did lead him down the thought path to an excellent solution.

“I understand,” Mr. Transport said. “It’s just that Mr. Numbers is at a meeting and I do hate eating in restaurants alone. I always feel somehow out of sorts, as if I don’t belong as a solo diner. Silly I know, yet the sentiment remains.”

“No, I get that,” Vince said. “I guess I can come along. Eating alone

does kind of suck.”

“Much appreciated,” Mr. Transport said. “I’m ready whenever you are.”

“I’ve already got my shoes on, so I guess I’m ready to-” Vince said, then noticed he was standing in the sunshine, white sand beneath his feet and a crystal blue ocean before him.

“-go.”

## 95.

“So how have things been since the holidays?” Mrs. Daniels asked. She and Hershel were sitting in an Italian restaurant a few miles off campus. It was a quaint place with fair prices, good food, and comfortable chairs.

“Not too bad,” Hershel replied. “Roy’s actually been working hard in the combat class.”

“Roy will tell me all about what he’s been up to at length tomorrow, sweetie. I want to know how you’ve been doing.”

“Good, I guess. The classes aren’t bad so far, and there’s this river trip during spring break that looks like a lot of fun.”

“That’s nice. How about with girls? You talked a lot about you friend Mary over the break,” Mrs. Daniels pried.

“Well... we did sort of dance a couple of weeks ago.”

“A nice start. Then what happened?”

“Um, nothing. That was it, we danced a few weeks ago,” Hershel said, suddenly feeling a bit uncomfortable.

“I see.” Mrs. Daniels said. She took a long sip of her white wine. “Darling, you know I don’t want to intrude into this new life you’ve made for yourself, but would you be open to a little motherly advice?”

“...sure.”

“An object at rest will stay at rest. An object in motion will stay in motion, unless it is acted on by an opposing force. Time is a tremendously effective opposing force,” Mrs. Daniels said.

“I’m not sure I follow you,” Hershel said.

“Son, if you have momentum then don’t let time erode it too much. You danced with Mary, and from the smile when talking about it, you took it to have a romantic connotation. A girl expects a little continuation of courting after moments like those.”

“So you’re saying I should have asked her out?”

“I’m simply letting you know what a woman generally anticipates in the courting process,” Mrs. Daniels said with a soft smile.

“Gotcha,” Hershel said. He thought about her advice for a moment. “One thing. Roy never really does that. I mean, he’ll go for days without calling or even responding to the texts of girls he goes out with.”

“What your brother does isn’t really courting. It’s more... well, I can’t think of a polite word for it. Just trust me that I know more about nice girls like Mary than Roy does,” Mrs. Daniels said.

\* \* \*

“Breathtaking, isn’t it?” Mr. Transport said, admiring the blue waves crashing against the sand.

“Actually, yeah, it kind of is. Must be really far, though, given the fact that it looks like noon here and we left at dusk,” Vince pointed out.

“Very astute. We’re indeed some ways from home. Don’t worry, I have no intention of leaving you for any type of trial this time,” Mr. Transport said.

“Glad to hear it,” Vince said, genuinely hoping Mr. Transport was telling the truth.

“I’m sure. The sandwich shop is down the beach a bit. We can walk there in twenty minutes or so.”

“Sounds good,” Vince said. “Just curious though, you’re a teleporter, why not teleport us right to it?”

“Because then we wouldn’t get the experience of walking there,” Mr. Transport said.

Vince cast his eyes out at the ocean once more. He had to admit, he could definitely see the appeal of taking the scenic route.

\* \* \*

“That was delicious,” Mrs. Daniels said, pushing away her plate.

“I told you,” Hershel said. “This place is awesome.”

“It was; you made an excellent choice, dear. After this I’ll sleep like a baby tonight.”

“You’ll need it to keep up with Roy tomorrow,” Hershel said.

“Of that I have no doubt,” Mrs. Daniels agreed. “Speaking of, you boys worked out a schedule, right?”



“Yup. I’m here tonight and Sunday before you leave in the afternoon. Roy gets all of Saturday. It adds up to around a full day each,” Hershel explained.

“Sounds very fair.”

“It is. Roy’s actually been a lot more amiable lately,” Hershel said. “I think the training is giving him a place to take out a lot his... energy.” Hershel narrowly avoided using the term ‘anger’. It seemed closer to badmouthing someone than making a report.

“I’m happy to hear that. I hoped you boys would start getting along again eventually,” Mrs. Daniels said. “Most siblings are friendlier in their older years, anyway. I was counting a lot on growing up to help that process.”

“Might not have been a bad bet.”

“Your mother has her moments,” Mrs. Daniels said. “And I know a thing or two about dealing with strong-willed boys.”

\* \* \*

“You’re right, this sandwich is ridiculously delicious,” Vince said, the cheese oozing down from his first bite and running along the plate.

“I don’t often hop across the globe for poor cuisine,” Mr. Transport said, tackling his own meal.

“Is going farther harder?” Vince asked.

“Not for me,” Mr. Transport said, shrugging his shoulders. “I’ve heard others say distance creates difficulty for them, but it’s all the same to me. A mile or on ocean, I go there in a simple jump.”

“That’s weird. I never really thought that people with the same power would function differently,” Vince said.

“It’s a curiosity, I’ll give you that,” Mr. Transport said. “All I’ve been able to figure out is that there’s no such thing as ‘the same power’ among Supers. Vast amounts of similarities, but with subtle differences between them. For example, I once knew a large amount of fellow teleporters. One woman left a shower of sparks when she vanished. One man would appear in a large cloud of dark smoke. There was even a fellow who left the smell of sulfur in the air when he jumped. All the same power in a very technical sense, yet each as unique as the Super that wielded it.”

“I see what you mean. Sort of like how shifting is the most common

ability, but everyone shifts into something different,” Vince said.

“And even those who shift into the same basic form have differences between them. Two people who can shift into panther-human hybrids would still look quite different and possess individual strengths and weaknesses.”

“So you’re a teleporter who can go any distance with ease,” Vince surmised. “That doesn’t mean that every teleporter can, though.”

“Precisely.”

“I guess that makes you one of the better ones then,” Vince said.

“I’m okay,” Mr. Transport lied. “There’s always someone better.”

That last part wasn’t a lie, even if Mr. Transport didn’t know it.

## 96.

Nick was charming. Alice had never expected that sort of thought to cross her mind, yet as she watched him schmooze the conversation she had to admit the boy had his smoothness. It wasn't just that he was knowledgeable on every topic that came up, or that he had an impeccable sense of manners and propriety, or even his effortless likability. It was that he had all those things and understood how to control a conversation. Nick knew the art of not talking.

He spoke infrequently, never interrupting but only interjecting when a lull occurred. He splashed in a few words or a subtle idea and then retreated. It was a series of quick, delicate strikes that gave off the impression of a young man with a competent head on his shoulders who still properly respected his elders. Alice sipped her merlot (she'd been allowed a single glass at dinner since she was a young child), pondering just how it was that someone like Nick could so effortlessly become this amazing guy.

They were in a restaurant that catered to upscale clientele. As such, it was done in very dark, muted colors, lit by a soft glow of light that was just bright enough to see that one's food was properly cooked. It was a place that was easily missed, even by the locals, holding only a small placard on the door to indicate a restaurant was here. There were no prices on the menus and there was ample dust on the bottles. Alice used to love places like this, and while a part of her was always overjoyed at the prospect of food prepared by expert chefs, she found the atmosphere to be a bit drab. Somewhere amongst the gastrointestinal catastrophes that represented the dorm cafeterias Alice had grown accustomed to a dining environment that was more... lively.

"I must say, Nick," Mr. Vinders' voice blurted, breaking Alice's reverie. "You were quite right about the '62 merlot. I'd never ever heard of that winery before."

"Thank you, sir," Nick said, dipping his head ever so slightly in a gesture of humility. "It was just some knowledge I gleaned from an old teacher. It seems that particular regions of France experienced exceptional flooding about a year before, leaving it unable to grow or produce until 1962. When they finally did, they discovered that the rain had washed new minerals from a nearby village into soil, leading to exceptional wine."

"That's quite the useful knowledge," Mr. Adair said.

"I'm glad I was able to share it with you," Nick said with a smile. He

raised his glass and did a small toasting motion before treating himself to a sip.

“That’s quite a young man you have there, Alice,” Mr. Vinders said. “I wish my Beth could meet one like him.”

“*Father!*” Beth hissed. “I’m taking my time in choosing a worthwhile one.”

“You’ve had three years. Alice pulled it off in only one semester,” Mr. Vinders countered.

“I suppose Alice got the only good one,” Beth said, spreading her mouth into a smile while her eyes danced with rage at the happy couple.

“Keep trying. The sooner you get married the sooner you can leave that school. You’ll get yourself seriously hurt one of these days. I’d never have allowed you to attend Lander if I’d known they were letting women in the combat classes,” Mr. Vinders said. Nick began to suspect the large, mustached man had drunk a little too much of the sumptuous merlot. Fortunately, Mr. Adair was certain of that fact.

“I’m sure she’ll meet a kind boy soon,” Mr. Adair said. “Be glad she’s being choosy, though. After all, a man like you would surely reject ninety-nine percent of the boys who would try to date a girl as lovely as your daughter.”

“Quite true,” Mr. Vinders agreed.

“Thus it is both prudent and efficient for her to only bother bringing around the ones who truly have a chance at being worthy of her,” Mr. Adair said. “But I think that’s enough about our daughter’s love lives for the moment. Shall we get down to more immediate matters?”

“I’ve told you already, Charles, I’m not comfortable selling out my company unless I’m certain you won’t go on a firing and outsourcing spree,” Mr. Vinders said, his face immediately growing serious.

“I assure you, the headcount will remain unchanged should your company find itself in my employ,” Mr. Adair said. He reached out onto the table and plucked up a small black menu. “However, I find talks like best done between two gentlemen in solace, save for a good brandy. The immediate business I was referring to was dessert.”

“Ha!” Mr. Vinders let out a chuckle and slapped the table. In a fine dining restaurant, such a thing would have been unacceptable. In a place like

this acceptability was determined purely by whoever had the most money in the room. “Right you are, Charles. Let’s leave business for after we drop off the kiddies. At the moment I’d rather do some serious damage to a good crème brûlée.”

\* \* \*

Vince and Mr. Transport lounged in the straw chairs, resting their feet in the smooth currents of the ocean.

“This beats the cafeteria,” Vince said.

“This beats damn near everything,” Mr. Transport said. He took a long drink from the pink liquid in his clay cup. The punch was another specialty of the shop and a feature that made this slice of paradise even more enjoyable.

“Yeah, I’ll give you that one,” Vince agreed. “I do love the water. Makes me wish I was looking forward to the river trip more.”

“What’s wrong with the river trip? I’ve heard it’s a highlight of freshman year at Lander.”

“There’s going to be a lot of drinking,” Vince said. “I’m still figuring out how to be part of that whole scene when I don’t want to join in.”

“Just be,” Mr. Transport said. “Contrary to what after-school specials will tell you, people who are drinking don’t really care all that much if you’re not. It translates to more beer for them anyway.”

“Heh. I suppose that is a good point.”

“Why the hang up, though? I mean, most kids your age like to experiment a little.”

“Most kids my age haven’t spent their whole lives out of control,” Vince pointed out. “I’m a little worried that anything that messes with my brain chemistry will send me right back to where I was.”

“That’s nothing to worry about. We told you there’s no chemical compound that can change you back. You’re a Super for life.”

“Fear isn’t often rational,” Vince said.

Mr. Transport took another sip of his drink, mulling over Vince’s words. He then extended the cup to his silver-haired charge.

“Fear isn’t rational, but facing it can be,” he said. “Try a sip.”

“I’m... um, well I’m underage.”

“Actually, in this part of the world there is no legal drinking age, so no, you aren’t,” Mr. Transport said. “Aside from which, we’re surrounded by a small population and you’ve probably only got a little bit of energy stored up. I can easily teleport you somewhere deserted if you start blasting fire at the trees. There is literally no situation I can think of where it’s safer for you to take a sip of alcohol.”

“But why take the chance?”

“Because hopefully you’ll have a long life ahead of you, and in it there will be tons of things that might take away control. I’m not saying to get shitfaced or become a drug addict, I’m just saying that I’d rather not see a kid like you spend his life always afraid that fun will automatically be punished by a return to a shittier point in life,” Mr. Transport said.

Vince tentatively reached over and accepted the cup, then took a short sip. He handed it back to Mr. Transport, who took a much larger one.

“That was actually pretty good,” Vince admitted.

“Yeah,” Mr. Transport agreed. “Feeling like you’re about to blast the shit out of something accidentally?”

“Not yet,” Vince said, settling back in his seat. “I think we better relax by the ocean for a bit longer though, just in case.”

“Good idea.”

\* \* \*

“Charles, do you mind if we borrow the limo for a bit so I can drop my daughter off and say goodbye?” Mr. Vinders asked as they pulled up to the parking lot nearest Melbrook.

“Not at all,” Mr. Adair said. “It will give me a chance to say goodnight to Alice as well. Swing back by when you are done.”

“Of course,” Mr. Vinders agreed. Mr. Adair, Alice, and Nick all departed from the limousine. It pattered off slowly across campus, aimed at a different housing area.

“So good to see you again, dear,” Mr. Adair said, hugging Alice lightly.

“You, too, Daddy. Feel free to come visit again.”

“I will keep it in mind,” Mr. Adair said with a smile. “If it isn’t too much trouble, may I ask the chance to speak privately to your boyfriend?”

“I really don’t think you need to do that,” Alice began.

“It is every father’s right to put a touch of fear into his daughter’s suitor,” Mr. Adair said, turning toward Nick.

“It’s fine, Alice,” Nick assured her, flashing a confident and relaxed grin. “I’ll be inside in a minute or two.”

“Nick, you really don’t need to-”

“Don’t be silly,” Nick said, cutting her off. “A gentleman covets the right to speak earnestly with his lady’s father.”

“Um... okay... I guess,” Alice said. She walked slowly back to Melbrook. Both Nick and her father kept her in their peripheral vision until she was in the door, but neither took their focus off the other. It was only after the door had solidly shut behind her that words were at last spoken.

“You’re not actually dating Alice,” Mr. Adair said simply.

“You’re going to slash the shit out of Mr. Vinders’ company,” Nick replied.

Mr. Adair raised an eyebrow. “What makes you say that?”

“You called first, you show your hand,” Nick said.

“Fine,” Mr. Adair agreed. “You’re too smart for her, she was too comfortable when you touched her around her father for there to be any legitimate intimacy, you don’t particularly care for her, and she was not nearly nervous enough. Shall I continue?”

“No,” Nick said. “That was good. You’re a smart man and a good liar.”

“That’s how you knew I plan to gut the company?”

“Yes. Remove humanity and it’s a simple business decision. I’m sure you’ll find a fancy way to word the contract, but it was a simple deduction to make. It’s what I would have done,” Nick said.

“That might be the first thing you’ve said all night that I believe,” Mr. Adair said. “Your act did cheer my daughter, though, so I suppose I owe you some thanks.”

“Consider the meal thanks enough,” Nick said. “Are we done here?”

“Depends; are you planning on chatting up the younger Vinders and letting her know about my business intentions?”

“Not even slightly,” Nick said. “You played along with my ruse, I’ll ignore yours. You were wrong about something, though.”

“Do tell.”

“I care enough about Alice to tell her father what a bastard he is for baiting and switching the poor girl with a visit like that.”

“She loathes business dinners and I needed her attendance in order to secure the meal,” Mr. Adair said unapologetically.

“I didn’t expect you to be sorry,” Nick said. “Just felt you should know that you’re an asshole.”

“Nothing new, I assure you,” Mr. Adair replied.

“Good. Now we’re done,” Nick said. He began walking toward Melbrook. As soon as he opened the door he saw Alice waiting, pacing along the floor.

“How was it?”

“Standard dad stuff,” Nick said, slipping into his usual persona. “Touch my daughter wrong and I’ll have the FBI and the CIA erase you from existence. Nothing new.”

“That’s good at least. A little surprising from him, but good.”

“Yeah. Now, if you don’t mind, that heavy meal has me tuckered out. I need to get some sleep,” Nick said.

“Oh yeah, no problem,” Alice said, stepping out of his way. “But I just wanted to say thanks.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Nick said, waving her off. “You saved my life, it’s the least I could do.”

“I know, but... still.”

“We’re cool, Alice,” Nick said gently. “Helping each other in rough spots is what friends are for.”

Alice smiled. “I’m starting to realize that.”



## 97.

"Sounds like you did a real good thing," Gerry commented as he chomped into the greasy, cheese-soaked burger before him.

"Sure, it was a great thing. I showed one of the people I live with that there's more to me than the persona I've been rocking all year, I spent the evening with some truly boring people, and I managed to call one of the richest man on the planet an asshole," Nick summed up. He fiddled with his sunglasses, getting used to them once more. "It was smart choices all around."

"You called him an asshole while sticking up for his kid," Gerry pointed out. "There's thankfully few fathers in the world who can hold a grudge against that."

"He very well could be one of them," Nick said. "What's done is done, though. Alice's night was a lot better than what it would have been without me."

"I'm proud of you, Campbell," Gerry said sincerely.

"Glad to hear it, because I think we both know I didn't do all that for her," Nick said.

Gerry simply nodded his head. "So what else is going on this weekend?"

"Tomorrow... well, I guess today now," Nick said, checking his watch. It was past two in the morning. "Anyway, today they take the parents down to the underground levels and show them their kids' classrooms. There's a cute speech by the dean and the opportunity to meet the coaches. For the less trusting of parents I'm sure they can ask for progress reports as well."

Gerry wrinkled his nose. "Seems more like high school than college."

"Agreed, which is why we won't be attending. Honestly, I think they only do it because it's more palatable for a parent to actually see what their child is going through rather than just know they're being trained in some mysterious program. Giving them a weekend is the path of least annoyance for the school," Nick speculated.

"You're probably dead on with that one," Gerry agreed. "So if we're skipping the function, what did you have planned?"

Nick shrugged. "Nothing too exciting. I thought we'd jump in my car

and I'd show you the town."

Gerry laughed. "How about we take mine instead? I got a real nice one from the rental company."

"You trying to say something about my ride?"

"Not at all, kid, not at all. Did you end up going with the 'won it on a slot machine' lie?"

"Yup," Nick said.

"Why not just tell people you bought it? Tons of kids buy cars, it wouldn't have made you stand out," Gerry said.

Nick shook his head. "Too responsible. I'm trying to capture the image of a guy who is irresponsible and flies by the seat of his pants. Planning and saving for a car doesn't mesh as well as just cheating and winning it."

"Fair point, I suppose," Gerry agreed. "Still not sure why you insisted on a Bug, though."

"I can't win too much. If I'd brought back a Ferrari or something people would have felt jealousy. Winning a Bug, though, that's a cute anecdote at best."

"I see where you're coming from, but it still makes me chuckle," Gerry said. "I mean, if I told the girls that Nicholas Campbell was driving around in a Bug, they'd bust a gut laughing."

"Which is why it will never leave Lander, right?" Nick asked.

Gerry gave Nick a big smile. "I'm waiting to see your grades before I go making any promises."

\* \* \*

Alice still couldn't sleep. She'd drifted off from time to time, but the rest was always shallow and the dreams too vivid. She had tried a glass of milk, a warm shower, and even counting sheep, yet sleep was still remaining elusive to her. The most troubling part was she knew exactly why. She couldn't sleep because of Nick.

Alice had grown up with her only social interactions taking place in the world of high society. She'd met with diplomats, entrepreneurs, and politicians, and had slowly learned to see through the lies in their smiles. They were all two-faced, and eventually Alice was able to penetrate their

disguises, noticing the small tics and habits that didn't go along with the person they were pretending to be. She'd thought herself quite good at it when she arrived at Lander, ready to classify and manipulate everyone in sight. She hadn't been prepared for what greeted her, an entire mass of people her age who didn't bother with such pretense. Most of whom couldn't, actually. It seemed like people were more occupied with finding out who they were than in deciding who they wanted everyone to see them as.

Maybe that was why she had missed it; she'd eventually stopped looking after weeks of seeing no double faces. No, that wasn't it. Blaming her lax observations didn't give enough credit where it was due. Sure, she'd stopped trying to see through people, but even if she'd been on top of her game all the time Alice was certain Nick still would have slipped by her.

He'd always been the same guy. Smarting off, acting up, making stupid comments and organizing waste-of-time events. Even the stupid glasses were just him wanting to be noticed. Yet tonight, he'd taken them off and effortlessly been someone else. Someone charming, smart, sophisticated, and amiable. There had been no trace of the old Nick, from the way he moved to something as simple as opening a car door. Everything he did had suited this new persona of his. Had she met him for the first time tonight, she would have never imagined the version she'd known for the last several months could exist.

So now, Alice was laying in her bed staring up at the ceiling, unable to find sleep. Was she that much worse at seeing through people than she thought, or was Nick that much better than she was? Either way, it was curious. Under any other circumstance she would have banged on Mary's door to compare notes and try and put things together. It didn't feel quite right, though, not when he had shown Alice this part of himself in order to help her. She wouldn't go around stirring up trouble for him in response to his kindness. She would keep her curiosity and observations to herself.

One thing was certain, though: Alice was definitely paying attention again.

## 98.

“Thank you again for taking the time out of your lives to come and visit us here at Lander University,” Dean Blaine said, circling the group back to the lifts where they had entered an hour and a half ago. “This concludes our tour of the facility, and I hope you all now have a greater understanding and appreciation for the education being taught to your children.”

The tour had gone off pretty well; they almost always did. The gyms were closed, no classes were held, and every non-freshmen student had their ability to use the lifts disconnected for two hours when the parents were wandering around. It was always officially billed as “technical difficulties”. The older students, however, had long ago reached the obvious conclusion: nobody wanted a problem to occur when outsiders were around.

This crop had been well-behaved, and Dean Blaine was letting out mental sighs of relief that he would soon be passing the buck to George and Persephone.

“Now, we’ve reserved a dining hall just for you folks today where you can eat with Coach George and Coach Persephone,” Dean Blaine explained. “You can talk with them about your children or just relax and meet the other parents. The whole area will be secure, so there’s no need to worry about spilling the beans on any student’s secret identity, though I would remind you that outside of there and here, utilizing the utmost discretion is advised.”

The parents nodded appreciatively and began filing toward the elevators. As they moved past, Dean Blaine made an effort to see which group of adults was with which student. A dean should be able to recognize his charges’ families, after all.

It was clear not all of the students had come, though more had turned out than usual. Dean Blaine noticed Shane DeSoto walking to lifts with his older sister and their parents, as well as an older gentleman. There was something slightly familiar about the older man, but Dean Blaine couldn’t place it before he was out of sight. It seemed Roy Daniels was here with his mother, a dowdy woman with a persistent smile. Looking at her, it was hard to believe she’d raised a child as rambunctious as Roy, though it explained quite a bit about Hershel. Sasha Foster had both parents with her: a middle-aged couple that had been particularly wide-eyed during the tour.

“Blaine,” said a soft, familiar voice next to him, stealing him from his thoughts.

“Miriam,” Dean Blaine said warmly. “I was hoping you’d stop to chat before you left.” He clasped the woman’s hand briefly and squeezed, only for a moment.

Miriam was middle-aged and holding up well under her years. She had shoulder-length blonde hair and tan skin from a life spent living near the ocean.

“Of course,” she said, returning the smile Dean Blaine hadn’t realized he was giving. “I know we can talk to the coaches, but I wanted to speak with you directly and see how things were going.”

Dean Blaine glanced at the platforms carrying parents and students back to the surface. It was slowly thinning the crowd. There were clearly several trips left, though.

“I’d love to, Miriam. This is probably not the best place, though. Would you like to join me at my office?”

“That would be fine. Thank you, Blaine.”

“Will he be all right?” Dean Blaine asked.

“Certainly. I’ll let him know I’d be meeting him a bit later for lunch,” Miriam assured the dean.

“Excellent, well then, let us away,” Dean Blaine told her.

The trip was short. Dean Blaine’s office was relatively close to the lifts, just in case he needed to get out in a hurry. That feature seemed to smack more of the “abandon ship” mentality than Blaine preferred, but he hadn’t been around when they designed the place and it would be an enormous hassle to fix now.

They entered the office door and Dean Blaine poured them both a drink. He already knew how Miriam took her scotch, so he didn’t bother asking. Many things about people might change as the years wear on; however, that feature seemed to remain constant.

“Thank you,” Miriam said, accepting the glass. She glanced inside. “Halfway full with three cubes. Impressive.”

“The important things tend to stick in my head,” Dean Blaine said as he settled into his high-backed leather chair. “So, tell me how you’ve been.”

“As good as can be expected,” she said. “I went back to school and got my nursing degree a few years back. Now that I’m alone in the house I’m

thinking about downgrading to a condo. I haven't told my son yet. I'm not sure how he'd take his childhood home being swept out from under him."

Dean Blaine smirked. "You managed to steer us on topic remarkably quickly. Okay, let's talk about your son." He reached into his desk drawer and rummaged around briefly. Within a few minutes he extracted a manila envelope. Dean Blaine set it on the table and skimmed the contents. He already knew most of them off the top of head.

"Chad Taylor," Dean Blaine said, reading off the front page. "Currently ranked top of his class in combat. Tested exceptionally well during the first semester finals. Expected to easily stay at the top of the class when the next trials are held at year's end. As for above ground, he's pulling straight A's. All in all, he's a model student."

"I knew all of that, Blaine," Miriam said. "I was more talking about how he's adjusting to being here. You know, seeing his father's alma mater, walking the same halls, taking the same classes. I wasn't sure how he'd acclimate."

"I think he's doing fine," Dean Blaine assured her.

"Define 'doing fine' for me, please. Does he have any friends?"

"Certainly; he spends most of his time with Shane DeSoto and Michael Clark," Dean Blaine said.

"I see. And what are the ranks of these boys?" Miriam asked.

"Um... well, two and three, respectively."

"So he has training partners," Miriam assessed with a sigh. "I suppose asking about a girlfriend is out of the question, then."

"To my knowledge he hasn't become intimate with any of the female students yet," Dean Blaine admitted.

"How about male? I'll take what I can get here."

"Miriam..."

"Oh, I know, I know," she said. "It's just frustrating. He's such a good boy, yet all he does is think about training and getting stronger and being like his dad. You know he didn't apply to any other schools? Only Lander."

"We do have a very prestigious reputation."

"Come on, Blaine, Lander is great but the other four schools give out

Hero Certifications just as valid as yours. Everyone hedges their bets.”

“Perhaps Chad simply knew he would be able to take his pick,” Dean Blaine suggested.

Miriam shook her head. “No, it was because he wanted to go to the same place. If you’d turned him down he would have just kept applying, year after year until you let him in. He is stubborn as a drunken mule.”

“I suppose that makes his path toward emulating his father at least a little bit shorter then,” Dean Blaine said.

Miriam let out a short, barking laugh. “You may have a point at that.” She set her glass down and glanced at her watch. “I really should be getting to that lunch now.”

“Of course. I’ve got some things to do as well,” Dean Blaine said, shuffling papers that were previously arranged quite correctly.

“I appreciate you humoring me checking up on him,” Miriam Taylor said, rising from her seat. “I just worry. You know how it is.”

“Indeed I do,” Dean Blaine agreed.

“I hope to see you again before I leave. If not, at least you’ll be coming around for Easter.”

“About that,” Dean Blaine said haltingly. “Now that I’m an authority figure over your son, I’m not sure if that’s such a good idea.”

“Nonsense,” Miriam said. “You got off the winter holidays with that excuse and I’ve been kicking myself for letting you ever since. You’ll come to Easter at our house in a few months and you’ll bring your famous chocolate pies. Not one argument about it.”

Dean Blaine contemplated protesting, then thought better of it. “You win as usual, Miriam. Have fun at lunch.”

Miriam wrinkled her nose. “Blaine, have you forgotten I went to Lander too? I know what to expect from the food.”

## 99.

"This is certainly... colorful cuisine they serve," Mrs. Daniels said, working her way through the plate. "Do you happen to know if anyone horribly offended the cooks in some way?"

"Nope, that's just dorm food," Roy said. "We don't have to eat here, though; we can go anywhere you want."

"Don't be silly, this is fine," Mrs. Daniels said. "Besides, I want to talk to your coach and see how things are going."

"There's no need, they're going great."

"Then you must be anxious to hear him tell me that himself," Mrs. Daniels said knowingly. "It looks like the crowd is thinning out. You stay here while I go speak with him."

"Yes, ma'am," Roy said. He stayed put as his mother got up and stood in line with the other parents. His stomach twisted a bit. Yeah, he'd been able to keep up with the poundings Chad had been delivering for the past few weeks, but he still hadn't gotten a hit off yet. That had to reflect badly on his overall performance. Not to mention that fact that he'd only participated in one challenge battle last semester and had gotten his ass kicked. Sure, his grades had been all A's; but that had been all Hershel's doing. Much as he would deny it if anyone asked, Roy wanted to make his mother proud, too. Now he had to trust in a progress report that would be delivered by Coach George of all people: the man who seemed least impressed by Roy's substantial abilities out of anyone. This was going to be a bad day.

\* \* \*

"Mrs. Daniels," Coach George greeted, shaking her hand carefully. "Pleasure to meet you."

"You too, Mr. George, but how did you know who I was?"

"Just George is fine, and I make it a point to know the names and faces of all of my students' parents," Coach George explained. "In case one of them tries to jump me."

"That seems a bit paranoid," Mrs. Daniels said.

"It would be paranoid if I was doing it before any such situation had occurred. After that it's called learning," Coach George countered.



"I... see. At any rate, if you know who I am then you know who I'm asking about. How is Roy doing in class?"

"How can I put this?" Coach George said, pressing his thumb to his jaw as he pondered. "Your son is arrogant, pig-headed, vastly overestimates his abilities, and spends too much time chasing tail instead of training. I've been expecting him to wash out since the first week, and at the beginning of this semester I even put him up against the strongest kid in the class to see if he would flush down the drain once and for all."

"I'm not sure how to—" Mrs. Daniels began. Coach George cut her off with a quick raise of his finger.

"*But*, he is also incredibly resilient, unrelentingly determined, and has shown a tremendous amount of humility in accepting lessons from those who have proven themselves his better. When I challenged the combat class to take me on, he was the first one to step up, and that takes some courage. He's been getting the stuffing knocked out of him five days a week since the spring semester began and every day he shows up asking for more, and he does it because he understands that each day makes him a little bit better."

"So what are you trying to say here?" Mrs. Daniels asked.

"I'm saying your boy has plenty of flaws, and very well might not make it all the way to being a Hero because of them. He also has steel in his spine, fire in his gut, and balls the size of watermelons. Those might take him to the top. Honestly, it's just like the rest of this program: it will depend on the work he puts in," Coach George explained.

"Thank you, George," Mrs. Daniels said. "That was enlightening."

"Glad to keep you in the loop," Coach George said with a smile.

"It was appreciated," Mrs. Daniels said, turning to leave. "Have a nice day. I hope none of the parents jump you."

"That will be seen," Coach George said. "Not everyone got such kind reviews of their kids as you."

\* \* \*

Roy's nervous waiting came to an end as he saw his mother leave Coach George's side. He clamored to his feet as she walked back over.

"What'd he say?" Roy asked, poorly hiding the nerves in his voice.

"About what I expected," Mrs. Daniels replied. "That you're good, but

if you want to be the best you still have a long road ahead of you. Although he said it in an exceptionally vulgar way.”

“Yeah. That’s Coach George,” Roy said.

“He also mentioned you seemed to be dating a lot of nice young girls. Do I get to meet any of them today?”

Roy, yes, Roy Daniels, blushed. “Nah, Mom, it’s nothing like that. I just have a lot of female friends.”

“Mmmhmm. If that’s what you want to go with...” Mrs. Daniels said.

“It really is.”

“...then I suppose we can skip over it for now. Besides, I think we’re done here. Now, how about you show me the town?”

Roy let a big grin break across his face. “It would be my pleasure.”

## 100.

“That bad, huh?” Nick asked.

“Yeah. I spilled my tea, accidentally tripped the waiter, and briefly set the table on fire when I knocked over the centerpiece candle,” Vince said. “So her family is not all that fond of me.”

“I never thought of you as all that klutzy,” Nick said.

Vince shrugged. “I’m not normally, but I was so nervous about meeting my girlfriend’s parents for the first time I just got flustered.”

Nick and Vince sat in the common room, the Sunday afternoon light shining on them through the windows. All the parents but Hershel’s had departed; he was saying goodbye to her in the parking lot currently. Alice was catching up on homework in her room and Mary sat in a chair nearby, reading.

“You’re still a nice guy, though,” Nick pointed out. “I’m sure her parents were just glad she was spending time with a quality fellow.”

“They kept mentioning a nice young Super her uncle knew with coordination and exceptional powers. They were adamant she meet up with him for coffee next time she is in town.”

“Wow, they are not fans of fumbling,” Nick said.

“Yeah. Apparently they’re all about powerful Supers good enough to breed with their daughter. Weird thing, though, as bad as last night went, Sasha was exceptionally affectionate when we kissed goodnight later on,” Vince said.

“You really are clueless, buddy. Think real hard about why a girl with dyed-pink hair might actually be happy to find out the guy she’s with was not well-liked by her parents. When you come up with a theory, get back to me,” Nick instructed him.

“I don’t see why the hair is important, but okay,” Vince agreed.

The sound of the front door opening interrupted them as Hershel walked in.

“See your mom off?” Vince asked.

“Yup,” Hershel confirmed. “It was nice to see her, but it’s sort of

weird having her around in this environment.”

“Tell me about it,” Nick agreed. “Gerry’s a good guy, but he was all sorts of cramping my style. Didn’t want to hit strip clubs or cock fights or anything.”

“The visits all passed without any terrible incidents or blown secret identities, so I think we can chalk this weekend up as a win,” Hershel said.

“I’d wait to hear Vince’s story about dinner with Sasha’s parents before I made that statement,” Nick said.

“Bad?” Hershel asked.

“I’m seventy percent sure they tried to sneak out and ditch me when I went to the bathroom,” Vince said.

“That’s pretty bad,” Hershel surmised.

“What about you? Roy didn’t get your mom into a biker brawl or tossed in jail or something?” Nick asked.

Hershel laughed. “Roy? Roy loves our mother. They spent the afternoon touring little niche shops downtown. He’s a model son when she’s around.”

“Huh, and there you go,” Nick said. “Well fellows, we only have a little bit of weekend left. Anyone up for video games in the boys’ lounge?”

“Normally I’d say no, but with everyone gone I was able to catch up on my all homework already, so why not?” Vince agreed.

“Sweet. Hershel?”

“I’ll join up with you guys in a few minutes,” Hershel said. “I have to take care of something really quick.”

“Cool deal,” Nick said, pulling himself from the couch. He and Vince headed into the boys’ area, the steel door locking firmly shut behind them.

Hershel took a deep breath. He wasn’t good at these sorts of things, that is to say, brave things. He preferred to let Roy handle that sort of thing. Hershel was the brain and the heart, Roy was the brawn and the guts. It wasn’t a perfect arrangement, but it had sufficed for many years. There was a flaw in that system, though. It didn’t account for when Hershel needed bravery for something only he could do. Admittedly, such a scenario hadn’t really come up before now.

Personally, Hershel blamed his mother. She'd put the thought in his head, and it had stewed about all weekend. By the time he'd kissed her cheek goodbye, he had come to the undeniable realization that she was right. Admitting that was unfortunate, because it demanded action. He had to make a choice, and even if he did nothing, he now knew that was a choice in itself. Hershel no longer had the convenience of self-deception. The only question left was if he had enough courage of his own to take the risk. Well, to be fair, that wasn't the *only* question left.

"Mary?" Hershel said shakily, walking over to the chair where she was sitting.

"Yes?" She looked up at him and set the book on her lap.

"I was wondering if you would like to go out sometime to do something with me if you wanted."

Mary arched an eyebrow. "Could you elaborate?"

Hershel's stomach began gurgling. He sent it a mental note that it could complain and vomit in stress all in wanted in five minutes, but for now it should please shut the fuck up.

"I want to take you on a date." Hershel's eyes widened slightly: that was more straightforward than he'd been shooting for. Still, it was out there now.

A slow smile crept across Mary's face. "I'd like that. What did you have in mind?"

"Um, just dinner on Friday. Off campus, of course. Around seven?"

"Works for me," Mary said, straining to keep her own voice even and calm. "It's a date."

"Awesome," Hershel said. "I mean, cool. It'll be fun. Yeah... I'm going to go play video games with Nick and Vince now. But I'll see you on Friday."

"We live in the same dorm. I'll see you before then," Mary pointed out. "I get what you mean, though. See you then."

"Right," Hershel said. He then, in an act of wisdom well beyond his years, immediately retreated to the boys' lounge before he could say anything stupid and mess things up.

For her own part, Mary waited until she was sure Hershel was staying

behind in the other room before bolting out of her chair and dashing into the girl's side, banging on Alice's door.

Interestingly enough, both sides had similar reactions to the news.

“About freaking time.”

## 101.

“So you finally did it,” Nick said, slapping Hershel on the back. “What gave you the kick in the pants?”

“Something my mom said, actually,” Hershel admitted.

“Make me grandbabies or don’t bother coming home?” Nick asked.

“A touch more tactful than that. She just pointed out that it wasn’t going to get easier at this point, and the longer I waited, the worse my chances got.”

“Good for you,” Vince said. “I bet you two have a great time. What are you planning?”

“Just dinner,” Hershel said. “Someplace kind of nice, probably.”

“Classic start,” Nick said. “Then what?”

“I don’t know... digesting?”

“Right. Let me get this straight. You’ve been trying to ask this girl out for over six months, you finally got up the courage and she agreed to be your date for an evening, and you don’t plan to do anything besides go to dinner and come back?” Nick asked.

“It sounds really lame when you say it.”

“I can’t imagine why,” Nick said, shaking his head. “Hershel, my boy, I don’t know a lot of things about women. I know they like chocolate, shoes, and movies that induce crying. I know they get offended if you ask if their behavior is due to a regular monthly occurrence. I know that some of them get a little violent if you try to give them an innocent nickname.”

“Sugartits isn’t what I’d call innocent,” Vince interjected.

“Stay on subject, Silver. My point is that I know precious few things, but one of those is that a woman expects a little woo to be pitched on a first date,” Nick said. “Assuming you want there to be a second one.”

“I would very much like there to be a second one,” Hershel said.

“Then we better get brainstorming, because a girl like Mary is going to take more than a chicken parmesan and some kind words to win over,” Nick said.

\* \* \*

“So where do you think he’ll take you?”

“I’m not sure. Someplace nice, I’m sure, but hopefully not too fancy. I’m a simple girl, and I think Hershel knows that,” Mary said.

Alice nodded her head in agreement. “He seems to be slightly less thick-headed than the other men we’re surrounded by.”

Mary laughed. “They might surprise you. Some of them are actually quite sharp.”

“I’m sure,” Alice said. Before she would have brushed off the comment as Mary being good-natured. Now, though, she once again found herself thinking about Nick’s little transformation. Even if he could lie that well, there was no way he could keep it from Mary’s telepathy. She had to have some inkling of what was going on in the head behind those sunglasses. Sadly, this wasn’t the time to ask her about it. Right now was about Mary... and Hershel, to a similar extent.

“Any clues on where he’ll take you after dinner?” Alice asked.

Mary blinked. “After?”

“Yeah; I mean, he asked you on a date. You don’t think he’s planning on just driving to get food then coming back and saying bye do you?”

“Sort of. Yeah,” Mary admitted.

“Ah. Dates usually consist of more than just food. At least first ones do, anyway. It’s the guy’s chance to really show you how awesome he is, so they love doing it up big,” Alice explained.

“I see. I suppose that doesn’t seem so bad,” Mary said. “You know a lot about dates.”

“Only second-hand. The few times I ever ‘went out’ with a guy were formal dinners when my dad wanted me to charm the son of some CEO or royalty,” Alice said. “They were pre-arranged events with chaperones and the guys were always boring as hell.”

“That bites,” Mary said.

“It did, but who cares? Those days are long since past. Now let’s focus on you, little missy. Have you picked out an outfit yet?”

“I was thinking... the peach-colored dress?” Mary ventured very



tentatively.

“Hmm. You know, that would work nicely,” Alice said.

Mary let out a sigh of relief.

“...as a start,” Alice continued.

“A start?”

“Sure, it’s a base layer. Dressing up is all about picking a base then building tasteful accessorization on top of it,” Alice explained. “Don’t worry; we’ve got nearly a week to play around with all kinds of combinations. By the time Friday night gets here we’ll have gone through every conceivable variety of outfit and picked the absolute best one.”

“Oh joy.”

\* \* \*

“So we’ve ruled out comedy clubs, movies, miniature golf, and strip clubs, though the last was under extreme protest,” Vince surmised.

“It’s a touch of daring and adventure!” Nick proclaimed. “Plus it puts the sex issue right on the table. It’s perfect!”

“It’s done, Nick, let it go,” Vince said. “We’re on to new suggestions now.”

“I’m running dry,” Hershel said. “You and Sasha have been together for a while now, what kind of first date did you take her on?”

“I just did dinner,” Vince said. “This whole woo pitching thing was news to me, too.”

“Wait, you did just dinner?” Hershel turned to Nick. “If he got away with it why can’t I?”

“Several reasons,” Nick said. “For one, the whole lovably clueless thing works for Vince.”

“I’m not clueless,” Vince protested.

“Whatever you say, Cupcake. You don’t have that type of charm. You’re a smart, good-hearted guy. That means you’re expected to do your research and put out some real effort,” Nick said.

“I guess I can see that,” Hershel agreed.

“Secondly, ask yourself something. This is your first date with a girl you really like. Do you want to ‘get away’ with half-assing it or do you want to leave her speechless?”

“Okay, okay. Point taken. I have to do more than just dinner. But we still haven’t answered the question of what,” Hershel said.

“I keep telling you guys, there is a gentleman’s club south of town with exceptionally reasonable steak prices on Friday nights.”

“Still no on that one.”

“I think you have to ask yourself less of what you’d like to do and more of what Mary would enjoy,” Vince said. “It’s about impressing her, so it needs to be something she’d have fun doing.”

“Carnival?” Hershel ventured.

“That would actually work... if there were any going on right now,” Nick said.

“Damn. This is a lot harder than I thought it would be. Roy always made dating seem effortless,” Hershel said.

“That’s because Roy didn’t care, so he didn’t put in effort,” Nick pointed out. “That’s another type of charm, though, once again, a type you don’t have.”

“Relax, Hershel, you’ve got most of a week ‘til Friday. I’m sure you’ll think of something,” Vince assured him.

“And if you don’t, there’s always steak and tits,” Nick tossed out. “Just saying.”

## 102.

Mary returned home from class on Tuesday to find Mr. Numbers setting up the chess board in the common room.

“Is it Saturday already?” Mary asked.

Mr. Numbers shook his head. “We missed our weekend game. I thought we might play today instead.”

Mary paused for a moment, then walked over and set down her bag. “Why not?”

Mary made the opening move, followed by Mr. Numbers. In the time they had been playing she’d been slowly growing better. She was lasting a move or two longer each game so far, though Mr. Numbers anticipated her progress would reach a plateau within another five games.

“So, what’s on your mind?” Mary asked as she shifted her knight’s position.

“Just the game.”

“Now, I think we both know that’s a lie,” Mary said.

“Listening in?”

“Not during our games, no. But I’ve heard you long enough to know you’re a creature of habit, and you’d rather miss a game than reschedule it,” Mary said.

“True,” Mr. Numbers said. “Mr. Transport and I have been entertaining the idea of another project, one that would require the assistance of you and Nick.”

“I should warn you, I’m still putting extra blankets on my bed and drinking my tea hot as symptoms from the last ‘project’ you two hatched.”

“It’s nothing like that,” Mr. Numbers assured her. “This one would be both harmless in nature and universally beneficial.”

“I’m sure.”

“Are you willing to hear me out?”

“Yes,” Mary said. “If for no other reason than I’d rather be forewarned and forearmed.”

Mr. Numbers carefully ran through the plan Mr. Transport had presented him some days before. He was careful to include every detail he had currently determined and to be absolutely truthful. Even if Mary really wasn't listening in right now, that didn't mean she wouldn't be checking in on him in time to come.

"I like it," Mary said. "And I'm on board for it. I can't speak for Nick, though."

"I daresay no one could claim such an ability," Mr. Numbers remarked.

"Maybe, maybe not. Either way, you'll need him," Mary said.

"I was unfortunately certain you would say that."

"You're good at what you do. Anything else I should know?" Mary asked.

"Indeed. Checkmate," Mr. Numbers said, moving his bishop and springing the trap he'd laid.

Mary blinked. "Did you distract me with this just to beat me?"

"Don't be silly," Mr. Transport said. "It was a necessary conversation. And I don't need cheap ploys to beat you."

"Yet," Mary said.

Mr. Numbers looked down at the small, unassuming girl and the confident look in her eyes. His brain buzzed, assessing the multiple factors he'd gleaned about her. Her ambition, her determination, her aptitude, and her focus.

"Yet," Mr. Transport agreed, sweeping up the board and heading into his room.

\* \* \*

Nick was relaxing in the common room later that night, flipping through television stations, when a flash of blonde hair and pink dress dropped into the seat next to him.

Nick raised an eyebrow. "Can I help you?"

"What?" Alice said. "Can't a girl sit down and watch some TV with her friend?"

“That depends,” Nick said. “Is there a reason she needs to do it right next to him, as opposed to in one of the many other scenic locations?” He gestured at the empty common room and the abundance of seats contained within it.

“Oh no, I think proximity is very important. It fosters deep, intellectual conversations. Conversations about new developments, and what those new developments might be doing this weekend,” Alice said.

“You want to know where Hershel is taking Mary on Friday.”

“See, I always told people how smart you were,” Alice said.

“Liar.”

“Admitted,” Alice said. “But I still want to know, so spill it.”

Nick laughed. “And why would I betray the secrecy of my dear friend for the curiosity of a girl who repeatedly hits me?”

“Well,” Alice said, leaning forward slightly. “Maybe because a gesture of that sort would make her feel better disposed toward you. Maybe she’d show you a softer, kinder side.”

“Yeah, not buying it.”

“Fine. Then how about maybe because she’s right next to you with her hand in punching range of your crotch?”

“Now, see, that, that I believe,” Nick said, shifting his legs slightly to provide cover. “Even if I wanted to tell you though, I can’t. As of when I last checked, Hershel doesn’t even know what he’s going to do with Mary after dinner.”

“That sucks,” Alice said. “He better think of something soon. Mary’s looking forward to a good night out.”

“I’m sure our little nerd boy will come through in the clutch,” Nick assured her. “He can be tenacious when the mood strikes him. Plus, Vince and I offered up a veritable plethora of helpful suggestions.”

“Please. You probably suggested something moronic, like taking her to a strip club.”

“I would never!” Nick cried in a hurt tone. “I can’t believe you think so little of me.”

“Uh huh. Whatever you say, stud. Let me know if he tells you

anything,” Alice said, getting off the couch.

“No promises, but if it’s exceptionally interesting I might seek you out,” Nick said.

“That’s probably as good as I’m getting out of you,” Alice sighed. “I’m going to go work on some chemistry. Night, Nick.”

“Night, Alice,” Nick said, giving her a perfunctory wave. Once the door was closed, though, worry descended on his face. She’d been much more comfortable and familiar around him than normal. The whole mock flirting thing had demonstrated that amply well. Such an attitude could be problematic. The last thing he needed was her to grow so at ease around him their friendship developed into romance. No, it was best to nip this in the bud right away.

Nick flipped out his cell phone and selected a number from its directory. That was the good thing about catching these situations early, they could often be resolved in a single phone call.

## 103.

The concrete crunched under the forceful impact of Roy's substantial form crashing against it.

"Getting tired?" Roy croaked from his prone position on the ground. "That last one lacked your usual flair."

"Did it?" Chad asked. "I'll be sure to make up the difference on this one."

"I appreciate it," Roy said, pulling himself vertical. "I'm not here for the B course after all."

Chad did something then that Roy hadn't seen from him so far, something to his knowledge no one had witnessed.

Chad laughed.

"You know, for all of your flaws, you've got tenacity," Chad said, chuckling to himself. "It's refreshing, even after all these weeks. I'd started thinking there was no one who could take my strength and keep coming."

"And all this from the guy who wasn't even worthy to fight you," Roy said, smiling as he tried to get his feet steady.

"Indeed," Chad said. "It almost makes me wish you were on my level. I think fighting someone with your resolve at a higher talent level would benefit me greatly."

"Then you take this as a Roy Daniels promise: when I'm stronger than you, I'll still be your sparring partner."

"I appreciate the intent," Chad said, taking a stance as he prepared to bring Roy down again. "You do know that you'll never be better than I am, though, don't you?"

"I know that you think that," Roy said. He charged forward, left arm swinging around at Chad's head. Chad easily stepped to the side, caught Roy's arm, and wrenched it around to his back.

"With moves like that, you'll lucky to even land a blow on me before the year's end," Chad said. He expected Roy to make another witty comment before Chad swept his legs out from under him and deposited him on the ground. What met his ears was something entirely different.

“AAAAAAAAAAAAAH!” Roy released a gut wrenching scream, one that tore at his very vocal chords. Chad was taken by surprise. He was behind Roy, pulling Roy’s left arm to his back against Roy’s considerable struggling, ready to send him sprawling. It should have hurt him, yes, but not nearly enough for a reaction like that. Fleeting Chad wondered if his continuous beatings had somehow left lasting nerve damage that the healers hadn’t gotten. It was only a half second of doubt and confusion, yet almost instantly Chad realized what it had cost him.

The fingers of Roy’s right hand wrapped around Chad’s left bicep. Chad felt the arm in his grip dangle weightlessly, his hold no longer effective as Roy turned around to face him.

“You... ripped your entire left arm out of socket?”

“And screamed loud enough to distract you while I did it,” Roy said. “See, for guys with our kind of strength, it’s hard to tell the difference between regular struggling and bone-shattering effort. It all feels the same weighed against our power.”

He was right. Chad had felt him bucking against his grip, but Chad had assumed it was merely his usual boisterous escape attempts.

“A good point,” Chad said. “Now what, though? Your left arm is useless and you know I’ll break that grip you have on me in no time. You still can’t win.”

“Newsflash, Blondie,” Roy said, gritting his teeth through the pain that his left arm was broadcasting. “I’m not trying to win.” In one motion Roy jerked Chad forward, digging his hand deep into the arm and pulling forward with all his weight. Chad braced himself for a throw, reaching out for Roy’s shoulder to reverse it before he was airborne. That was to his detriment, because too late he realized the meaning of Roy’s words.

“Dodge, fucker,” Roy said, slamming his head directly into Chad’s temple. The world dissolved into static and Chad’s head swam in pain. He wasn’t so far gone that he forgot his years of experience, and by the time his vision cleared he had placed Roy back onto the concrete with considerable force.

“You lose, yet again,” Chad said, his vision clearing to reveal a badly-battered Roy coughing up blood from the ground.

“Yeah, I do,” Roy said, his voice ragged. “But I hit you.”

Chad felt a soft trickle of blood run down his cheek. He sealed the cut



on the side of his head immediately, but there was no denying the damage that had been dealt.

“You tore your arm out of socket and sacrificed every advantage in our confrontation just to land one blow?”

“Damn right,” Roy said, pushing himself up with his right arm. It took him a moment to get standing, but he made it eventually. He faced Chad once more, right arm pulled into a fighting position, left arm dangling uselessly at his side.

“That was an insane gamble,” Chad remarked.

“It wasn’t just some gamble. I’ve paid to attention to your favorite moves in response to how I come at you. I’ve watched your style all these weeks, and I knew if I ran at you dumbly, you’d put me in a lock before dropping me. I had a feeling you’d defend against a throw over a headbutt, too.”

“What made you assume that?”

“Because you fight with polish and tactics, and you always go for the win. People like you defend like the other guy has the same thing in mind. It would never occur to you that I’d be going for a head-butt instead of trying to toss you out of the circle and win,” Roy explained.

“Because it’s ludicrous,” Chad pointed out.

It was Roy’s turn to laugh. “Yeah, yeah it is. But it worked.”

Chad shook his head. “I suppose it did. So you finally hit me, Roy. Now what?”

“Now I go for two,” Roy said, flexing his right hand and cracking the knuckles.

One minute ago Chad would have dismissed such a notion as sheer foolishness. Now, he merely nodded and took his own stance. Roy Daniels was lacking in training, refinement, and overall skill, but he had determination in spades. Chad knew firsthand how dangerous that particular quality could be. He wouldn’t be underestimating his opponent again.

“Whenever you’re ready,” Chad said.

## 104.

“How do I look?” Hershel asked.

Nick made a twirling motion with his hand, which Hershel obliged by slowly spinning around in place. He was wearing a hunter green button-down shirt, khaki pants and loafers. It wasn't the most fashionable outfit possible, but for a guy who wore shirt with dice on them, it was one hell of a step up.

“You look great,” Vince assured him.

“Almost perfect,” Nick agreed. He stepped forward and slightly adjusted the angle at which Hershel's shirt was tucked in. Neither Hershel nor Vince could see any difference when Nick stepped back; however, he seemed quite pleased with himself. “And there we go. You're ready for a night on the town, you lady killer.”

“Heaven deliver us from such nicknames,” Vince said. “Let's go over the list again. You have your wallet? Your cell phone? Nick's keys?”

“Check, check, and check,” Hershel confirmed. “And thanks again for the loan.”

Nick shrugged. “I can't let you take out a girl like Mary on Roy's motorcycle. She deserves more class than that.”

“Agreed,” Hershel said.

“Just be safe with my car. I don't fancy going back to walking my happy ass everywhere.”

“Will do.”

“So, did you ever think of a good place to take Mary after dinner?” Vince asked.

“Sort of,” Hershel said. “I have no idea if she'll like it. It's all I could think of, though, so I guess it has to work.”

“Any hints on what the brave act of desperation is?” Nick asked.

Hershel shook his head. “Nothing personal, but I want it to be a surprise. Mary doesn't read my thoughts, but she hasn't made any such claim about you guys.”

“A fair point,” Vince said. “And I think that's everything. Are you ready to pick up your date?”

“Dear god no,” Hershel said, clasping his hands to keep them from trembling. “But let’s go ahead anyway.”

“Atta boy,” Nick said, throwing his arm around Hershel’s shoulders as they left the boys’ lounge and entered the common room. “By the way,” he whispered, “I left a box of condoms in the glove box. Just tossing it out there if you need to know.”

“What happened to treating a classy lady right?” Hershel whispered back.

“Hey, I’m not making judgments or assumptions. I’m merely of the mind that it’s better to be safe than sorry.”

“Thanks, Nick. I think.”

With that they were in the common room, walking in on the sight of Alice standing in a very guard-like way by the girls’ side. She examined Hershel critically, her expert eyes assessing his ensemble and demeanor. Whatever test was being performed in that blonde head evidently culminated in Hershel passing, because she knocked twice on the steel door next to her and said, “He’s here.”

A moment later the door swung open and revealed a girl none of the boys could have immediately placed if not for process of basic deduction. Gone was the wild-haired girl who often wore outfits consisting of capris and combat boots. In her place was a petite young lady wearing a peach dress with her hair styled carefully. Her face was lightly dusted with makeup, gently accentuating the features her tussled locks often hid. She was a little bit taller, thanks in no small part to wearing heels for once, and the smile on her face was absolutely entrancing.

“Hi,” she said, fidgeting slightly as she stepped into the room.

“Hi,” Hershel echoed, his tone saturated in the same sense of sheer wonder that the rest of him was feeling. “You look really nice.” The boy had a talent at understatements.

“You, too,” Mary said. They continued looking at each awkwardly for a few moments more, though it in no way compared to the awkwardness the other three felt at standing around observing this haphazard attempt at romance. Eventually something in Hershel’s head snapped into place, and he extended his arm.

“Shall we head out?”

“Sounds great,” Mary said taking his arm. The other two boys would have had to stoop slightly to link arms with Mary, but for once Hershel’s vertical disparity was working in his favor. The well-dressed couple walked out the door, thought it was a slightly more complicated task than normal since they were now linked together.

“That was just plain adorable,” Alice said once they’d left the room.

“I feel like I just watched a pair of kittens wrestling playfully,” Nick said. “I’m not sure I like this warm feeling creeping up inside.”

Alice swatted his arm half-heartedly. “You know you’re just as happy as we are that they’re finally going out.”

“He talks a tough game, but he ran Hershel through the ringer getting his outfit right,” Vince said.

Had Mary been there she would have slammed Vince into the ceiling and proceeded to detail all the different fashion combinations Alice had forced upon her during the last five days, showing no mercy until he had a whole new appreciation for what “going through the ringer” was really like. Since she was otherwise happily occupied, the comment went unpunished.

“You got me, I’m a big ole softy,” Nick said.

“I don’t know about that; however, I’ll give you points for loaning your car to Hershel,” Alice admitted.

“Why not? He’s a careful guy, and it’s not like I’ll be using it tonight anyway. My date is driving. Oh, that reminds me, I need to go change before she gets here,” Nick said, glancing at his watch and dashing off into the boys’ lounge once more.

“Ugh, that is so like him,” Alice said. “He does one nice thing, but he put off getting himself ready and now some girl will have to wait- HIS WHAT?”

“His date,” Vince replied helpfully. “Didn’t he tell you? I guess Hershel’s bold move finally put the right spring in his step.”

“Right. Just so we’re clear here, this is Nick we’re talking about, right? Nick has a date?”

“He sure does,” Vince said.

Alice’s next words were careful, measured, and calm. That should have tipped off Vince that this news was not being nearly as cheerfully

received as he might have imagined. Vince being... well, Vince, the verbal cue went unnoticed.

Alice let out a deep breath. “With who?”

## 105.

So far Hershel was surprised at how easily his date was going. The conversation was flowing easily now that they'd gotten past their initial awkward hurdle and Mary seemed to be genuinely enjoying herself. This put the part of him that had been secretly wondering if she had accepted his invitation out of pity at ease. The small boost in confidence helped him return the volley of words, and thus increased the fun Mary was having. It was a self-perpetuating cycle, but an exceptionally enjoyable one.

"Hmm. The steak looks really good," Mary said, glancing over the menu for the first time since they'd arrived.

"It's what they're known for," Hershel told her.

"Well then, I think I'll give it a try," she said, setting the menu back down. "It's been too long since I had a well-cooked haunch of meat."

"Got a carnivore streak?"

"I did live in the woods for several years. Canned food can only get you so far and a girl has to eat," Mary said.

"I bet you throw one hell of a barbeque."

"You would not be disappointed," she confirmed. "Once it warms up again that might be a fun activity one weekend."

"Yeah, it would. Maybe they'll organize one for us. The school seems to be on top of it, what with the river trip and all," Hershel pointed out.

Mary wrinkled her nose. "I'm not sure if I'll be going on that. Much as I miss the outdoors, the things I enjoyed were the peace and serenity. I don't think I'm likely to find those things with thirty alcohol-saturated freshman splashing around."

Hershel nodded. "It's really not my scene either, but Roy is beyond-words excited about it."

"He has been good lately," Mary said with a sigh. "I suppose he deserves a break here and there."

Hershel winced involuntarily at the word "break."

"I'd say he definitely deserves a little time to cut loose," he said.

"And you're not just saying that because you get to share in the

memories of those loose times, huh?" Mary asked.

"Not at all," Hershel replied. "Roy has some fun, but I much prefer my own memories. Especially on nights like this."

"Very smooth answer, Mr. Daniels," Mary said. "Roy might have some competition for the role of charmer."

\* \* \*

"Wow, this place is really nice," Bubbles observed as Nick pulled out her chair for her. The restaurant wasn't actually all that high class, at least not by Nick's standards, but as he walked over to his own seat he decided he might as well roll with it.

"Just my way of saying thank you for your willingness to drive tonight," Nick said.

"Oh, it's no problem! I mean, if you'd already promised your friend he could use your car then that's how it is and you should keep your promises. Even when it's super inconvenient. 'That's a promise' means you'll do it no matter what."

"Indeed," Nick said, wishing dearly he had a fake ID and could order some wine.

"Besides, it's totally worth a few minutes behind the wheel to come out to an awesome place like this with you," Bubbles said, a rosy blush tinting her cheeks.

"You're sweet," Nick replied. "But I consider myself the lucky one. After all, I'm out with the most beautiful girl in the whole restaurant. And she's a Super at that."

"No way, I'm barely a Super at all. I mean, yeah, I love my power and it's really cool and fun, but let's be honest here: I'm not going to be saving any babies trapped in a fire or knocking out bank robbers. When I was little I kept thinking my power would bloom into something really cool and then it never happened and I was bummed for a while but then I kind of figured it's easier to be a normal girl than a Hero anyway and that's when I got okay with it."

"That's a very mature attitude," Nick said. "And for the record, I think it's an amazing ability. It must be a tremendous feeling to conjure something out of nothingness."

"It's pretty cool," Bubbles agreed. "I didn't use it too much first

semester though cause I was really scared of showing to someone in the HCP and getting laughed at.”

“HCP? Oh, that’s right, Lander has a program for Supers, doesn’t it?”

“Oh yeah, it’s a big deal in the Super community. The ones who are in it keep themselves a secret, though, so it could totally be anyone you meet on campus,” Bubbles explained.

Nick raised an eyebrow. “Anyone, huh? So you’re telling me I could very well be sitting with a bona fide Hero in training right now.”

“As if. I hear that thing is crazy hard anyway. I’m much happier being a regular girl with something extra special about her,” Bubbles said chipperly.

Nick smiled. “I can see the appeal there. We normal people just have to find our specialness in other places.”

“So what makes you special then?”

“I am spectacular at blackjack,” Nick replied.

“I’ve heard of that; it’s the game that’s like Go Fish, right?”

“My dear girl, I have so very much to teach you.”

\* \* \*

“You know, I’m really not used to surprises,” Mary said as Hershel piloted them around town in Nick’s car. “I’d be perfectly okay with you telling me where we’re going.”

“No way,” Hershel said. “I get to be possibly the first boy to surprise a telepath. You think there’s any way I’m passing on that honor?”

“Honor, huh? Someone is feeling confident.”

“Well, it has been a good night so far,” Hershel pointed out. It had been, too. The longer he’d been out with Mary the more they’d fallen into the comfortable rhythm of friends. There was still a romantic element to the evening, but the thing about knowing someone for several months is that changing one aspect of being with them doesn’t affect the entire existing dynamic. People who are friends don’t shift to entirely different individuals when they date; they merely become friends who are involved.

“Besides,” Hershel continued, “I could either be upbeat or worried, and worried seemed like it would have kind of dragged down the night.”



Mary giggled. “You make a good point. I still want to know where we’re going, though.”

“And you will. Just as soon as we arrive,” Hershel assured her.

Mary stuck out her tongue at Hershel, an act made all the more humorous by her prim and proper appearance. She really did want to know, but it bears mentioning that at no point did she ever consider reading his mind to find out. Well... not seriously consider, anyway. As far as Mary was concerned, tonight she was a normal girl on a normal date.

“We’re here,” Hershel said, pulling Nick’s car to a stop.

Mary peered out the window; a small twinkle of lights set against rolling waves of darkness greeted her.

“The docks?”

“The docks,” Hershel confirmed. He opened the door and stepped out, the salted air washing over him. It was a familiar, comfortable feeling. He’d thought all week about what to do with Mary after dinner, and on Thursday he decided to engage in a favorite activity to clear his head. The thought right on the heels of that decision was why not kill two birds with one stone and bring Mary along? After all, it was a fun activity, outdoorsy, and something Hershel had a bit of talent in.

“I’d like to point out that you specifically requested I not read your mind, refused to tell me where we were going, and then drove me out to the docks at night,” Mary said as she left the car and joined him. “Just saying, this looks a lot like the start to one of those horror movies Nick loves.”

Hershel laughed. “Mary, you’re the strongest girl in our class. If Roy couldn’t beat you, what chance do I have of pulling off something underhanded?”

“A fair point. I would still like to know what we’re doing here, though,” Mary said.

Hershel held out his hand. “By all means.”

Mary slipped her smaller digits into Hershel’s and the two began walking toward the water.

\* \* \*

“This place is so pretty; it reminds me a lot of the woods near where I grew up but I mean, obviously smaller, and not as woodsy, but I still like it,” Bubbles said. She and Nick had finished dinner and were walking through a local park. Unlike Hershel, Nick hadn’t put a tremendous amount of effort or thought into his post-dinner activity.

“I’m glad you enjoy it,” Nick said. “I come here when I’m feeling particularly far from home or thoughtful. The sounds of nature always makes me feel centered.” Nick deftly avoided tripping over a small bump in the

worn dirt path. Between the unfamiliar terrain and those stupid sunglasses he was having a hell of a time not tumbling all over the place. In retrospect, he was glad he'd made a trip here the day before to ensure the park was well lit and fit within the desired aesthetic parameters. If it were any darker he'd have to shed his shades.

"Oh my gosh that is so deep. I wish I did stuff like that but when I get bored I just go out to the club with L-Ray or play racquetball or make pasta or watch TV or-"

"We all have our own ways of dealing with stress," Nick assured her. He had already learned the same lesson many had before: when it came to Bubbles, one had to own the conversation or it turned into a monologue. "There's not a better or worse. It's like people, we're all unique, but that doesn't make anyone superior. Just different."

"I can see that," Bubbles agreed. "Talking about different, though, can I ask you something?"

"Of course."

"Not to pry, and if it's something serious like a scar or something I am sooooo sorry, but I'm really curious and I want to know and not that they don't look great on you cause they totally do, but why do you wear sunglasses all the time?"

Nick weighed his options. He had a few standard lies he used depending on the person asking. For Bubbles one of the less complex answers was likely the best route to take.

"My eyes have a photosensitivity condition," Nick told her. "It's not a big deal, but it means I get some pretty bad migraines if the light isn't dimmed and filtered. My lenses stop that from happening."

"That totally sucks, were you born with that or did something happen?"

"Born that way," Nick explained. "Like I said, it isn't really that big of a deal. I can take them off if the occasion demands, I just leave them on as a general rule for my own comfort. Besides, after all these years my glasses feel like a part of me."

"I totally get that, I mean, I wore the same shoes for three years and they were just, like, a part of my life and when they finally fell apart I didn't know what to do and I went barefoot for like a week before I could finally feel comfy in new ones. They look good on you, though."

“Well then, it’s a win all around,” Nick replied. He hopped at the last second to dodge a dip beneath his foot. Maybe he should have picked a slightly easier-to-navigate terrain.

\* \* \*

The sea sprayed upward, leaving a fine mist in the air that lingered on Hershel and Mary’s skin.

Mary let out a delighted squeal as the winter water touched her face. Her body was wrapped in a protective poncho that Hershel had stashed in Nick’s trunk, keeping her clothes safe from soaking. She’d left the hood down, though, preferring to feel the air run through her locks, absolutely wrecking the style Alice had worked so hard to craft.

Hershel adjusted their course slightly, moving toward a calmer patch of water.

“I still can’t believe I never knew you sailed,” Mary said, adjusting her grip on the bow of the small boat Hershel had procured.

“My mom taught us when we were younger. Lake Michigan was a nearby and we’d spend our summers out on the water,” Hershel explained. “It was always made me feel great, so the first week we were here I looked up a place I could get on the water if I needed to.”

“And this is the first time you’ve used it?”

“Second,” Hershel said. “I came out here around our third week in, when things were getting really stressful. After you put Roy in line, life got a lot more manageable, though, so I haven’t needed it.”

“I think I’d be out here quite a bit, need it or not,” Mary said, a wave knocking against the side and shifting her balance.

“Yeah, I thought the same. But things get busy, and time slips away from you,” Hershel sighed.

“I’m glad you took me out here tonight,” Mary said, looking over at him.

Hershel knew a goofy grin was splitting his face, and he sincerely did not care. He looked back into the amber eyes that he’d been unable to get out of his mind since his first day at Lander.

“I wanted it to be a special night,” he said.

“Mission accomplished,” Mary replied, an equally silly smile on her

own face.

## 107.

Hershel and Mary were the first ones back. They still smelled of salt and were lost in a conversation that had been uninterrupted for the past hour when they stepped into the Melbrook common room.

“So, I guess this is good night,” Hershel said, realizing there wasn’t much of a dropping off at the door opportunity.

“Looks that way,” Mary agreed. “I had a really good time.”

“Me, too. Would you be interested in doing it again sometime?”

“I think you’ll find me receptive to the idea,” Mary said.

“How’s next weekend work for you?” Hershel asked.

“Not great,” Mary said.

“Oh. What’s wrong with it?”

“Just seems like an awfully long time to avoid you,” Mary pointed out.

Hershel chuckled. “Okay, okay, you got me. Guess we’ll be seeing each other tomorrow and Sunday. I’m not sure how to really proceed from here. I’m sort of new at this.”

“I wasn’t exactly prom queen myself,” Mary said. “I think we should try to do more nights like this, where it’s just us and we have the romance and all, and then the rest of our time together is just that. Time spent together.”

“Sounds good,” Hershel said. “I think this might be one of those things we’re supposed to figure out as we go along.”

“It’s to my understanding that that’s supposed to be part of the fun,” Mary said.

“Then I’ll look forward to it.”

“That makes two of us. Good night, Hershel.”

“Good night, Mary,” Hershel replied. He very much wanted to kiss her in that moment, standing there in their dorm common room, the memory of the ocean still fresh in their minds. Instead he pulled her in closer and squeezed her tightly into a hug. Roy would have gone for the kiss, of that Hershel had no doubt. But Hershel wasn’t Roy, and tonight, for the first time

in a very long time, Hershel was happy about that fact.

They released each other and parted, going back to their respective sides of Melbrook and into their rooms. Mary was surprised not to find Alice waiting to hear all about the night out. Had she been less preoccupied through the week and kept better tabs on Nick, then Alice's absence might have been anticipated. As it was, Mary went into her room and reluctantly headed for the shower. Much as she loved the smell of the night ocean on her, it was hardly hygienic to go to sleep with so much salt on the skin.

\* \* \*

Nick and Bubbles arrived about an hour after Hershel and Mary.

"This place is really nice!" Bubbles remarked as they entered the common room. "And there's only, like, five of you? That is so cool, how did you swing getting into a dorm like this?"

"Just good luck," Nick told her. "As I've heard it was originally built for faculty; however, they weren't so receptive to living on campus with students, and, well... waste not, want not."

"Still, it's super nice. I mean, I love living with L-Ray and all, but you guys actually have a kitchen. Plus it's so secure and off on its own, it's, like, a totally different world and ugh now I am so jealous,"

"This is just the central area. Maybe next time I'll show you what the rooms look like," Nick said.

"Next time?"

"Assuming you want to see me again, yes."

"Oh yeah, I totally want to see you again, what are you doing tomorrow?"

Nick laughed. "The rest of my weekend is sadly already spoken for by homework. I'll call you later in the week and we can work out the best time for us to go out."

"Sounds awesome!" Bubbles said. She then realized the level of her volume and the lateness of the hour and dialed it down a few degrees before she spoke again. "Tonight was really nice. Thank you for taking me out."

"Thank you for being my company. And driving," Nick added on.

"I guess I should be getting back then."

“Indeed, but we’ll talk soon.” Nick assured her. They walked back out the front to the front door, which Nick graciously held open for Bubbles. Once they were in the brisk night air, she turned around to thank him one last time. Before she had the chance, Nick’s hand ran lightly up her cheek and behind her ear, drawing her face close to his. The kiss caught her by surprise for a moment, then she melted into it.

They broke apart eventually, Nick planting a final kiss on her cheek, as if he was signing his name.

“See you soon,” Nick said, pulling away.

“Mmmhmmm,” Bubbles replied, her tongue still adamant about staying in make-out mode and not surrendering itself back to the mundane task of talking. In this Nick had accomplished something a multitude of teachers, parents, and friends had failed to accomplish. He’d rendered Bubbles speechless.

Nick stepped back into Melbrook and shook himself a bit mentally. It’d been a while since he had physical contact with a beautiful woman, and the first time he’d ever done so in his current persona. He should have held back a bit more. This Nick shouldn’t be quite so adept a kisser. He made a mental note for next time. It would likely be all right. If his skill level decreased Bubbles would almost certainly just assume her memory of the first kiss was rosily remembered due to the hormone cocktail most people knew as romance.

He walked down the hall and stepped into the empty common room once more. All in all the night had gone well. The girl never stopped talking, but Nick had excellent selective attention so he’d manage to stave off annoyance most of the evening. She provided excellent visual stimulation as well, to which he was never averse. Most importantly, Alice was nowhere to be seen, meaning she had either gone to bed or was talking with Mary. Either way, she wasn’t concerned with Nick Campbell, which was precisely how he wanted it.

Nick opened the boys’ side door and stepped in, greeted by Hershel and Vince, who were already discussing Hershel’s date. The door swung shut behind him on the common room, now empty once more.

\* \* \*

On this particular occasion (and countless other, less relevant, ones before it), Nicholas Campbell was wrong. Alice Adair was neither asleep, nor talking with Mary, nor even in Melbrook at all. She was currently floating



high above the Lander campus, clad in an enormous jacket, ski pants, and face mask to protect against the cold and the wind.

She'd dipped down momentarily when he and Bubbles had come home, not enough to make out words to but enough to see the show. She'd also seen Mary and Hershel arrive earlier. She thought about how she should probably be down there, talking with Mary and making sure everything had gone okay. She would do all that, too. She would just do it tomorrow. For right now Alice was floating through the air, truly enjoying her power for the first time since she'd gained control of it.

In a way it was a surreal experience. When she was Powered, happiness had always been what sent Alice airborne. Tonight, though, she was melancholy. Everyone was hooking up and becoming romantically involved, yet she was lagging behind. There was a fear snaking through her heart, one that said at this pace she'd find herself alone once more. She tried to calm it away, but it was persistent. It reminded her that even Nick had met someone. If he could get a date then it was only a matter of time until everyone was caught up in their budding romances. So she'd decided to get out of the house. Normally this would involve a drive down the highway. Tonight, though...

Alice rotated slowly in the air, staring up at the nighttime sky. It was breathtaking, the vastness of space made all the more real by the empty air beneath her. It was both humbling and inspiring. Alice drank it in, letting the wonder suffuse her. She knew she had to go in eventually, and she would. She'd shower to warm herself up, sleep late in the morning, then take Mary out for a girls' breakfast to hear all about the night. She'd face her slowly-growing fear of solitude by strengthening the bonds with those she found herself caring for. She would tackle everything facing her.

Just not this moment.

## 108.

Monday, as the freshmen finished their first two hours of gym, the combat class began heading toward the stairs while the alternative class moved to the empty side of the room. This had been their pattern since the new system began, so it was a surprise when Coach George moved between himself and the doorway to the stairwell, instead waving the students back.

“Not today, you little eager beavers,” Coach George said. “Line up with the alternative class.”

The students exchanged a few confused glances, but by this point Coach George’s most important lesson (Do what you’re freaking told and shut up) was starting to stick. They jogged over and lined up alongside the rest of the class.

“Today we’ll be introducing you to another kind of training, this one useful to Supers of all types,” Coach Persephone said once everyone was in place. “We’re going to work on ranged techniques. Expect to do this about once a week, though the exact day will be changed as George and I deem necessary.”

“Now,” Coach George said, stepping forward and taking over. “Some of you have powers that lend themselves to ranged attacks, some of you have powers that will lend themselves to it with a little teaching, and some of you have jack shit in that department. We’ll be splitting you into three-man teams based of which of these groups you fall into and getting you going in shooting range rooms. We won’t be supervising much, because this part is really simple. There will be targets. You will shoot said targets. New targets will lower, rinse and repeat until we come for you. Get into your teams as I call your names.”

The class barely had time to glance at their friends before Coach George’s barking voice filled the air.

“Smith, Griffen, Riley!”

Mary, Alex, and Adam all hustled toward the area and stood in a trio.

“Reynolds, Dixon, Wells!”

“Campbell, Reid, Weaver!”

And so it went until everyone had been crammed into a three-man unit, after which the coaches led them down the stairwell to a new level. This

one looked like nothing so much as a honeycomb of rooms. At each room a team was deposited with the same instruction: “Find the weapon that works best for you, shoot as many targets as you can, don’t stop until we come get you. You’re being watched.”

The rooms were stocked like a riot control officer’s wet dream. All variety of pistols loaded with rubber bullets, shotguns equipped with beanbag rounds, even a net cannon leaning in the corner. There were weapons of more lethal force as well, everything from throwing knives to hatchets. Most curious were the items that seemed to have no place in these rooms at all, like the sack of steel ball bearings or the roll of cloth bandages.

As for the targets, they amounted to what seemed like a very in-depth, well-funded carnie game. The targets popped out periodically from a shifting spectrum of cardboard buildings that acted as cover. The lights would pulse when a shooting session had commenced, alternating between blinding flashes and utter darkness. There would be minute-long breaks between these periods when reloading was expected to occur. The situation as a whole was frustrating, annoying, and left most of the students with a headache that would persist for the remainder of the day. The exercise bore fruit, though, as some discovered they had talent in this new form of battle, while others were finally able to showcase the skills they’d already developed.

\* \* \*

“Booyah!” Allen yelled, a bolt of green energy leaping forth from his hand and exploding against the cardboard cutout of a shadowy villain. Small burning chunks rained down on where the poor target had once stood, the only remnants of an inanimate object taken before its time.

“Not bad,” Amber admitted, stepping up to the front. “But still amateur hour. Watch how it’s done.” Amber closed her eyes and raised both hands, her middle fingers pressed against her thumbs. Her lips pursed and a low, almost undetectable whistle leaked out. The lights could flash all they wanted; Amber didn’t need her eyes to make these shots.

From Vince’s perspective, what happened next was inexplicable. Amber was still for a moment, then she began snapping her fingers on both hands. With each snap another target, often barely emerged from its cover, would explode into pieces. The lights stopped flashing after a mere twenty seconds of this, presumably because the system had to load more cutouts for them to shoot at.

“Wow,” Vince said. He’d assumed he would be paired with other Supers sporting ranged abilities, but he hadn’t imagined he’d see anything

like that.

“Respectable,” Allen said grudgingly.

“Thank you, thank you,” Amber said, opening her eyes and taking a few bows. She then glanced back at the wreckage that remained from her assault. “Sorry about that, Vince, didn’t mean to hog your turn.”

“I think it’ll be okay,” Vince said. “I’m sure there’s plenty more where that came from. I have to ask, how did you do that?”

“Ranged is sort of my thing,” Amber said excitedly. “I control sound waves, and those can be deadly, even over a distance.”

“Hang on,” Allen said, stepping up. “You’re telling you did all that with sound? I call bullshit, I didn’t even hear anything.”

“Of course you didn’t hear anything, Dumb-dumb,” Amber said. “When I snapped my fingers, it generated a sound wave. I amplified and focused that wave on whatever target I wanted to blow up.”

“Then we should have a really loud noise if you were amplifying it,” Allen pointed out.

This time it was Vince who corrected him.

“Sounds don’t work that way. What we perceive as ‘hearing’ is a wave coming in contact with our ear drum. If she was sending the whole wave to an individual spot then there wouldn’t have been anything left to reach us.”

“Very good, Vince,” Amber said. “You hit it right on the head.”

“I still don’t think I get it,” Allen said.

The lights began to flash once more.

“I can explain after class,” Amber offered graciously. “Right now I think it’s Vince’s turn to blow some shit up.”

“Um, thanks,” Vince said uncertainly. He had drained quite a few lighters recently, but he had a suspicion that if he didn’t finally use the electricity Coach George had mandated, he would be lectured about it at very loud volumes. Besides, this actually was a good learning opportunity. Up until now he’d just been absorbing from the battery, then recharging it at the end of class since powers had been off limits during close combat. Vince already knew how to shoot fire; today he could see how good he was with lightning.

Vince stepped up to the center area where the others had shot from.

The lights started pulsing and shadowy targets began to emerge and retract. Vince took a deep breath. Fire was wild, always aching to be let out. Shooting it wasn't hard, all you really had to do was take aim and let it run free. He figured electricity was pretty similar in a lot of ways, so his best bet was to try the same methods he'd developed for fire.

Vince focused on one of the center targets and raised his right hand. What happened next was pieced together by the remaining film footage, accounts from Amber and Allen, and analysis of what remained from the shooting area.

The consensus was that Vince raised his hand, and what sprang from it was something that resembled a tree made of light. The initial bolt of lightning got halfway to its target before several other bolts arced off it, heading in different directions. From those more bolts arced off, and so on and so on. This all happened in less than half a second, so to the mundane eye it merely appeared as if Vince had conjured a massive blast of lighting going in nearly all forward directions (it was exceptionally fortunate that Amber and Allen were behind him) that struck simultaneously the target, the cardboard buildings, the walls, and nearly every instrument that moved the cutouts, arcing through their wiring and into the power grid for the room.

In the localized power outage that followed, dimly lit by the burning remains of a few cardboard husks, it was agreed on all accounts that only a single word was spoken in response, and that it was spoken by Vincent Reynolds.

“Oops.”

## 109.

“I’m really not sure how comfortable I am with this,” Mary said.

“I’ll tell you, if I were in your shoes I’d feel the same,” Coach George agreed with her. “But this is the guy’s power, and we’re here to train everyone.”

“I’ll be right here the whole time,” Adam pointed out. “And I’ll turn back before we leave, so you can see everything I do and make sure it’s all on the up and up.”

“Still...” Mary said once more. She wasn’t just dragging her feet on this one out of concern of what Adam would do while occupying a duplicate of her body. It also scared her because she didn’t know entirely how his ability worked, and if he would duplicate her as she was now, or how she was before the procedure. Not to mention the fact that giving him access to her telepathy, even briefly, could easily unravel the secret of herself and the other Melbrook students. In short, there were just too many ways this could go wrong.

“Here’s the deal: he’s a boy and you’re a girl, so legally I can’t force you to allow him to mimic you,” Coach George said. “This is part of training mimics and absorbers, though, so try not to let your squeamishness have a negative effect on the learning opportunities of another student.”

“He could mimic me first,” Alex offered. “It doesn’t bother me.”

“Appreciated, Griffen, but we want to start him of learning how to control a... more traditional form of telekinesis,” Coach George said, skirting the issue. Griffen was a fine Super: George wasn’t going to go telling the kid he was a few macaroons short of cookie bouquet just because he needed to perceive his ability in a different light. Coach George was a results man, not one to get bogged down in the details.

“No, it’s okay,” Mary said with a sigh. Yes, it would be taking some significant risks, but she and the others had never really expected their secret would endure all four years. It had simply been nice to enjoy being like everyone else while it lasted. She couldn’t start letting it affect the training of others. They were here to learn how to be Heroes, after all. Every little piece of knowledge furthered that goal and it wasn’t her place to withhold such a thing from another student.

Mary extended her arm slowly. Adam gently took her hand in his and

focused for a moment. There was a soft tingle where his skin touched hers, and then Adam began to ripple as his bones and skin shifted. In mere moments, Mary was looking at an exact duplicate of herself, albeit with an oversized uniform since Adam normally had several inches on her.

Adam-Mary's eyes popped open, revealing identical amber irises, and gave Mary a smile. "I won't take too long," Adam-Mary promised.

Hearing her own voice out loud was such an unnerving experience that Mary almost hopped backward. Instead she marshaled herself and regained control. She placed some vacant, training-based thoughts at the forefront of her mind and returned the smile.

"Good luck," Mary wished her doppelganger.

"With power like yours, I doubt I'll need it," replied Adam-Mary.

\* \* \*

"That... that was just awful," Coach Persephone said as Nick lowered his pistol. "You actually managed to miss everything. By sheer chance alone you should have at least hit a building."

"Yes, thank you, we get the point. I'm a bad shot," Nick said, trudging back to the side and tossing his pistol in the pile.

"Bad shot? No, you are beyond a bad shot. You are a statistical anomaly of awful," Coach Persephone said.

"Maybe he was just nervous," Rich suggested generously. Gilbert, on the other hand, just beamed a giant smile as Nick was read the riot act. It wasn't very nice, he'd freely admit that, but Gilbert was still a bit sore at being punched and eliminated by Nick in the mid-term exam.

Coach Persephone raised her eyebrows. "Is that it? Would you like to blame your nerves, Nick?"

Nick shook his head. "Just a bad shot. We can't all be good at everything."

Coach Persephone stared at him for a moment longer, then turned her attention to the other two. "Right then. Well, I can only spend so much time with your team before I move onto the next one. Gilbert, wipe that grin off your face and let's see what you can do."

"No prob," Gilbert said. He pulled a revolver from the pile and comfortably twirled it down the length of his finger. "I've been shooting since

I was ten.”

“I’m far less concerned with how long you’ve been shooting than I am with how much you’ve been hitting,” Coach Persephone said.

\* \* \*

“Not too shabby,” Coach George said as Adam-Mary sent ball bearings through the center of yet another target. “You’re getting the hang of it.”

Adam-Mary had been going for around ten minutes and was getting a healthy competence with telekinesis. He had nowhere near the subtlety or precision a real user could produce, of course, but mentally hurling objects at high speeds was proving to be within his wheelhouse.

“That will do it on the girl,” Coach George announced as the flashing lights stabilized. “Time to try Alex.”

Adam-Mary nodded understanding and shifted back into just Adam.

“That does not stop being creepy, does it?” Alex asked.

“I’ve been told that no, it does not,” Adam admitted.

“At least you’re honest,” Alex said with a sigh, holding out his hand.

While Adam took Alex’s hand and began to shift into another person’s form, Mary let out the breath she’d been holding for several minutes. It looked like everything had gone over fine. She’d kept any shocking secret thoughts out of her head and Adam had turned into a perfectly-functioning version of her. As Mary relaxed, she realized just how much effort it was to be on mental guard around someone constantly. She’d experienced this secondhand while listening in on people’s thoughts, but living it for one’s self was a whole other story.

Adam-Alex had finished his new shift and was back in front of the target range. The lights began to pulse, the targets began to move, and then... nothing happened. Adam-Alex looked confused at first, then frustrated, and after a few more seconds a vein began to bulge in his forehead as his face grew redder. The lights eventually stabilized once more to find Adam-Alex staring intently at one of the hatchets, concentrating with all of his might, and finding absolutely zero success in moving it.

“I don’t get it,” Adam-Alex said at last, turning away from the instrument. “I was able to use her power fine, what’s wrong with yours?”



Rather than answer outright, Alex stepped over to Adam-Alex and began whispering in his ear. The words were hurried and soft, but Mary was positive she made out the word “force” somewhere in there.

“You’re joking,” Adam-Alex said, staring at Alex.

Alex shook his head.

Adam-Alex looked over at Coach George, who did nothing more than shrug. The lights began to flicker once more, and Alex stepped away from the central area.

“What do you have to lose?” Alex asked as he resumed his former position.

Adam-Alex kept his eyes trained on Alex for a moment, then, with a ‘what the fuck’ roll of his shoulders, placed his attention back on the hatchet.

Seconds later it whirled through the air, slicing neatly through a nearby target and wedging itself in the wall.

“I’ll be damned,” Adam-Alex said to no one in particular.

\* \* \*

“Again? You missed everything again? At this point I’m forced to assume that you are doing this on purpose,” Coach Persephone said.

“Oh yeah, because you railing on me for sucking is just my idea of an awesome day. Maybe next we can do the thing where you nerve stun me. You know, really put some icing on this cake,” Nick snapped back.

Gilbert and Rich stepped back involuntarily. They’d both done fine on their firing rounds; however, they weren’t entirely convinced that Nick’s poor aim and back talk wouldn’t result in a burst of ass-kicking that would find them twitching as collateral damage.

Coach Persephone felt a great temptation to oblige Nick’s request; however, she had been at this job for a long time and acquired many useful teaching tools. One of those was not beating the students unconscious every time she was provoked. Another was knowing when to take away an actor’s audience.

“Gilbert and Rich, go take a walk. Come back in ten minutes. I want to have a private discussion with Nick about the importance of a positive attitude,” Coach Persephone said.

The words were barely out of her mouth when the other two boys

finished bolting through the door. She couldn't help but smile a bit inwardly. After all these years she could still put the fear of God in her students when needed. Most of them, anyway.

"Okay, Nick," she said, softening her tone. "Let's talk, you and I. I understand that you aren't an exceptional shot, but why aren't you even trying?"

Nick raised an eyebrow. "How do you know I'm not?"

"Nick, your power is luck. Even if you were to do nothing more than shut your eyes, use your ability, and pull the trigger, you'd likely have at least a decent hit ratio. For you to miss every shot means you're not even putting forth that minimal amount of effort."

"Look, and I say this as respectfully as possible, I'm here to learn. And I mean that: I'm here to become as skilled and powerful as I can be. I'm not here to learn how to shoot people, though," Nick said sincerely.

Coach Persephone found herself genuinely surprised. She'd dealt with all kinds of attitude from Nick since she began working with him, yet she hadn't found anything like this yet. The boy didn't want to hurt people, so much so that he was refusing to learn a skill that could be turned toward lethal ends. It was a poor hang-up for a prospective Hero to have, yet it was one she respected all the same.

"Listen, I understand where you're coming from. There's a lot of pain and needless death in the world already. It can seem wrong that we're teaching those of you who are supposed to lessen those things how to kill. It bothered me when I first joined the HCP. What you need to come to terms with is that Heroes are defenders of the innocent from the wicked, and much as we wish otherwise, sometimes the bad guys just refuse to stop until they're dead. It's a harsh reality, I know. It's one you'll have to deal with eventually, though," Coach Persephone said, funneling as much understanding as she was capable of into her voice.

Nick cocked his head for a second, then let out something between a sigh and a snort.

"I think we just had a misunderstanding," he said.

"Oh?" Coach Persephone asked.

The lights began to pulse once more, indicating another firing round was nearly upon them.

Rather than stand with her, Nick walked over to the shooting area. From a nearby bin he drew a pair of medium-sized pistols, one in each hand. He sized up the weapons, testing their weight and balance in the time it took to raise them. What followed next was, unbeknownst to anyone in the room, a near repeat of Amber's stunt minutes prior. While Nick's shots didn't take every target, they did hit most of them dead center. The sounds of gunshots echoed off the small wall in a nearly continuous report until both clips were spent.

With a cold detachment and movements slick as an ice cube left on the kitchen counter, Nick finished off the last of his bullets and slid the guns back onto the table. He strode back over to Coach Persephone, whose mouth was slightly ajar.

"I'm not here to learn how to shoot, because I've been doing it since I was three. I was taught to be ambidextrous, to fire on the run, and to draw at speeds that made sure mine was the first shot off. Add in the fact that I can dose my rounds with a healthy burst of good luck and you understand why my bullets so often find their target. I was missing because I don't particularly like to broadcast that fact. It raises too many questions, and I hope you'll respect my privacy," Nick said simply. "If you have anything you think you can impart me to on being a better shot, I'll be glad to listen. Otherwise I'm going to go work on an area where I actually need improvement."

"Dismissed, for now," Coach Persephone said, her voice still recovering a bit from the surprise. "For next week's ranged training session we'll be graduating you to a more advanced shooting range."

Nick gave a nod of understanding and stepped out the door.

## 110.

Nick walked into the Melbrook dorm a few minutes later, thankful that the lift system could take him back to the top without involving Mr. Transport. He didn't expect anyone to be back yet, since they would actually be using this time for training, so it was a surprise when a voice called him before he could get over to the boys' side.

"Nick, may I have a moment?" Mr. Numbers asked, stepping out from the kitchen.

Nick sighed loudly and his shoulders slumped. He was only a few inches from the door. So close, and yet so far.

"Look, I know I should have just used the time and faked a few shots, but they were talking about doing this for an hour a week. That kind of time really adds up, and I feel like it's only fair for me to spend it actually improving myself," Nick said preemptively as he turned toward Mr. Numbers.

Mr. Numbers blinked twice. "I'm not sure what you're talking about, though I can assure you I will be before the end of the day."

"Awesome," Nick said.

"At any rate, I had something else I wanted to discuss with you. Something I'd like you to keep private from the rest of the group, excluding Mary," Mr. Numbers said.

"Oooh, now my curiosity is piqued," Nick said, a small grin growing on his face. Maybe this day would take a turn for the better after all.

\* \* \*

Vince was mortified. He sat in Coach George's office, waiting for the man to come in and let him know what the consequences from his accidental electrical outburst would be. There had been quite a bit of commotion after Vince had destroyed the power grid to the room, what with the small fires and people rushing in and what not. Vince had been hustled into this office and been told to sit tight. He wished they'd skipped the formality and told him to just pack his bags now.

The door slapped open as Coach George walked in. He was reading over a manila folder and collapsed into his chair without so much as sparing a glance for Vince.

“My goodness,” Coach George said. “You did quite a little number on that room. The whole thing is going to have to be rewired and rebuilt. Not too shabby.”

“Not too shabby?”

“Well, you didn’t blow a hole through the concrete, so I’m not going to go calling it great or anything. It was respectable, though, you earned that.”

“I’m... confused,” Vince admitted. “I thought I would be getting yelled at or kicked out right now.”

“Kicked out? For what? You did what I told you: you tried to use a new type of energy in an environment specifically designed for learning to use your powers,” Coach George said.

“But I messed up. I wrecked the whole room,” Vince pointed out.

“Oh yeah, you did screw up, no one’s fighting you there,” Coach George said. “But that’s part of learning. I mean, if we drummed out everyone who ever had a slip up the only thing battling evil would be an overinflated sense of ideals.”

“I guess, but, I just thought, I mean, there were all those other students who got dropped last semester...”

“Look, let me lay it out for you here. If you get lazy, or overconfident, or careless, then I’ll have you out of my gym with a fresh boot print on your ass. No one is going to kick you to the curb for making an honest mistake in the pursuit of learning, though. That’s how you get better at something: you screw up until you’ve learned not to screw up anymore. Let me ask you this, you going to try and shoot lighting the same way again?”

“God no.”

“Then lesson learned,” Coach George said, spreading his arms.

“So, if I’m not in trouble then why was I brought here to wait for you?” Vince asked.

“We wanted to make sure you were okay. Things like this can really shake some people up, so we try to be proactive and talk to you about it as soon as it’s happened. Put things in the right perspective and all,” Coach George explained.

“Oh. I guess that does sort of make sense,” Vince said.

“That it does,” Coach George agreed. “To that effect, though, do you

know what went wrong today? I mean, you nailed Castillo no problem during the exam, but this time it seemed to get out of control.”

“I’m not sure,” Vince admitted. “It could be a lot of things. Thomas was closer, so maybe it never had the chance to split. I had less power to use in the first place. Maybe even my state of mind. I wasn’t focusing on how to release the energy when I used it in the exam, I was just concentrating on getting the timing right. I can’t sincerely say where it went wrong.”

“That’s okay,” Coach George assured him. “It just means you’ve got a few more mistakes coming before you know how to handle this.”

“Oh dear,” Vince said.

“Don’t worry so much. Next time we’ll have you in a room where a mistake won’t be quite as alarming,” Coach George said. “Insulated walls, detached grid, grounded floors. Trust me, we’ve been doing this for a long time with a lot of Supers.”

“That might be okay then,” Vince said.

“Nice to hear you’re on board. Any other questions or things you want to talk about?”

“No, I think I’m all right for now,” Vince said.

“Excellent, then get your butt out of my office and back above ground,” Coach George said. “I’ve got paperwork to do.”

“Yes, sir,” Vince said immediately, scampering up from his chair and dashing out of the office.

\* \* \*

“It’s certainly contrived, and I can see why you’d want me and Mary helping,” Nick said after Mr. Numbers finished his proposal. “It could go over all right, though. Possibly even well.”

“Happy to hear you’re on board,” Mr. Numbers said.

“I haven’t actually said that yet,” Nick pointed out. “I’ve only said it’s logically sound in premise.”

“Then what’s stopping you?”

“As I told Mary, I don’t do favors. You want me to help steer things positively for you, then there’s something I want in repayment,” Nick replied.

“Dare I ask what?”

“Actually, nothing too complicated,” Nick said. “I want you to agree that at a point in the future, you submit to my request that you will refrain from interfering in whatever I am doing at the time.”

“I see. And if I don’t?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“Then neither do I,” Nick said. “That is the give and take of favors, after all. I would like to point out that I’m not asking for you to participate or intervene in any way with whatever activities I might be perpetuating: merely to do nothing. It’s even possible you would have done nothing anyway and I will have burned my favor pointlessly.”

Mr. Numbers carefully weighed his options. Making an open-ended deal with someone like Nick was far from desirable; however, the terms were slightly in his favor. It only required him to feign ignorance, turning a blind eye at some future point. Even if it was at a critical juncture, Mr. Numbers was confident he could stick to the letter of the deal while still circumventing Nick’s plans if needed. And worst case scenario, he could always just break his promise.

"Deal," Mr. Numbers said.

Nick spread a wide grin across his face. "Then it looks like we're good to go."

## 111.

Michael Clark was drinking again. He was alone in his dorm room, having paid the extra money to live without a roommate. He knew it was a bad habit for someone like him to have, and he sincerely had been trying to cut back, but days like this invariably seemed to find him at the bottom of a bottle. It was strange: he'd never had a drink before college, yet ever since some seniors had procured hooch for welcome weekend he'd been hitting the sauce with regularity. Had Michael known a bit more about alcoholism, he would have known he was genetically predisposed to it by way of his mother, but that was one of the many subjects Michael had never bothered studying.

He poured another glass of cheap scotch. Michael knew whose fault it was he was here tonight; it was the same as always. Vince Reynolds. Michael could feel the alcohol curdle in his mouth at just the thought of that name. That little son-of-a-bitch had shown him up on the first day, and even though Michael had emerged triumphant, it seemed like Vince was always nipping at his heels. Vince was ranked eighth even though he'd lost in the first round. Vince was dating the hottest girl in the freshman class. Vince lived in some fancy high-class private dorm with only four other students. Even today, Michael had been showing off his tremendous skill at ranged fighting. Everyone was impressed, and then what happens? They finish up and find out Vince had nearly wiped out an entire room, without even trying. Oh sure, he'd said it was an accident, but who would buy something like that?

No, Vince had wanted to show up Michael once again. Just one more time show that even though Michael was clearly better, Vince was the one who would get the attention.

Michael noticed his glass was empty and swiftly remedied that problem. Ever since that first day, when Vince had thought so little of Michael's abilities that he'd shown up with barely any energy to fight with, Michael had known what kind of prick that silver-haired douche really was.

And sooner or later everyone else would, too. Michael fully intended to see to that.

\* \* \*

Julia Shaw was painting her toenails a candy-apple red, watching television. She wasn't sure why she was bothering: boys never paid enough attention to feet and she didn't have any capable female competition to notice the cute little details. She shrugged and kept on with it anyway. Even if no



one else noticed, she still knew, and it made her feel pretty.

She glanced absent-mindedly at the clock. Ten until nine. If Roy was going to come over he wouldn't do so until ten thirty at the earliest. Hershel liked to study in the evenings, and Roy wasn't going to pick up the academic slack, so they usually didn't switch over until ten. Julia felt a slight tingle of frustration that she knew so much about the schedule of a boy she wasn't even dating. Not she wanted to date a hound like Roy anyway... okay, maybe a little.

He was just so much fun; it felt like every minute spent with him was energized and entertaining. Not to mention to things he could do in bed... Julia shivered involuntarily. She didn't think she could ever go back to boys that weren't Supers after so many months intermittently rolling through the sheets with Roy.

Julia smiled as she switched to the next foot. Hershel had told her recently that their situation was the longest Roy had consistently maintained a booty call. It wasn't the nicest compliment, she could freely admit that, but it was something. Julia felt she was far and wide the most capable virgin out there. She shared memories, sensations, and experiences with her clones, but she'd never known a man with her own body. That she was saving until marriage, just as the lord intended. Besides, when she could feel everything the clones felt anyway, what was the point in soiling her purity?

Julia finished the other foot and blew on it. They should be done by the time Roy might roll through. Even if they weren't, though, no harm done. It wasn't like it would actually be her own feet hiked over his muscular shoulders anyway. That was clone work.

\* \* \*

Will yawned loudly and set down the book he'd been flipping through. He slid his glasses down to the edge of his nose and massaged the bridge. Will had hit a wall earlier in the night and was trying to slowly bore through it.

Sitting in front of him was what might appear to the layman as a falconer's glove with wires running across and through it. In fairness to the layman, that's exactly what it was. Will stared at his glove-shaped obstacle and then turned his eyes away. Today's class had brought to his attention that while he'd created several devices for Jill to use, he was still lacking anything dependable in his own ranged arsenal. Sure, he could use one of the guns or throwing weapons they provided him, but that would be as good as stamping his own pass home.

Will was under no illusions. He was here because of his gift with technology. If he couldn't deliver in that department every time then there was no point for him to be enrolled at Lander. Not in the HCP, at least. So if he wanted to stay, he needed to show up to the next training session with a weapon all his own.

Will pushed his glasses back into their normal position and picked up the book once more. He wasn't going to sleep until he'd gotten at least three shots out of this thing. No compromises. No excuses. If Will failed out then Jill would be here all alone, and he'd promised a very long time ago to make sure that never happened to her.

Not again, anyway.

Will's resolve strengthened, and he began tweaking one of the circuitry systems. It sparked and sizzled in less than four seconds.

It was going to be a long night.

## 112.

Friday afternoon, as she trudged home from class, Alice had to admit she'd had better birthdays. She'd had worse ones, too, but those had been the ones spent at home. Since her father was usually off doing his own thing, Alice would take her birthday as an opportunity to go on a trip, seeing Tuscany or Paris or Venice, sometimes all of them in the span of a few days. She had to take precautions, of course - a Powered girl can't very well travel without some assistance in case of floating - but on the whole she'd still enjoyed herself immensely.

This one had been bleh so far. She'd been in a bit of a funk all week, ever since date night last Friday. The ranged training on Monday hadn't made things any better, reminding her once again of how useless she was compared to her peers. She would have hung out with Mary to make herself feel better, but the small girl had been occupied with something all week long. Vince and Hershel had become swept up in papers for different classes, and in a fit of desperation Alice had even tried to waste time with Nick. Sadly, even he was busy with other things, leaving Alice to her own devices.

When she'd come down from floating last Friday, Alice had convinced herself that she was overreacting to her friends going out on dates. It didn't mean they were going to abandon her or neglect their friendship. It just meant they had something new and awesome in their lives. Making her way slowly back to Melbrook, she was wondering if she had been right the first time. They weren't even walking with her today: they'd been off like shots as soon as gym had ended. She wasn't sure how they'd gotten out of there so quickly; Alice was almost certain she'd been in the first group up a lift.

She let out a breath, hoping to see it hang in the air. That time of year was done, though; the days were warmer with each sunrise. Too bad: Alice sort of liked the cold.

Perhaps she was taking this all too personally. It was college, people were bound to be busy from time to time. Besides, she hadn't even told anyone it was her birthday today. She could hardly blame everyone for not making a fuss when she'd never clued them in to why they should. They probably would have, too. Alice understood that, rationally. Somewhere in the back her head was a small voice that repeated the same question whenever she tried to cheer herself, though.

"What if they didn't?"

That's why Alice hadn't told anyone it was her birthday. Because right now there was an excuse for no one caring. If she'd said something and they still hadn't... well, then she might have had to face an unfortunate truth or two.

It was better this way, she assured herself as she neared Melbrook. Better to play it safe and maintain a medium level of happiness. Contentment had worked for her all her life, it would certainly suffice for today.

Alice opened the Melbrook front door and walked down the hallway. It seemed too silent for after class on a Friday. They should be on the other side of the door, watching television and making a ruckus. Hershel savoring the last few hours before he handed off the weekend to Roy, Vince and Nick debating how to spend the evening before eventually settling on something ridiculous, Mary sitting quietly and laughing at them all. Alice had gotten used to it. She supposed they were busy; even on a Friday they all had their own things to do. Alice wondered if it was too late to book dinner and a massage in town. That would certainly be a combination to lift her spirits. She reached the end of the hallway and pressed her thumb against the pad. It beeped and Alice stepped into the common room.

"Surprise!" The lights flashed on, though why they had been off was anyone's guess since the room didn't have any windows to the outside, and the Melbrook students leapt out from behind various pieces of furniture. Once again one could speculate on why they'd been hiding in the first place; however, one might conjecture that a surprise party has some conventions so inherent to it that they are obeyed even when non-applicable.

"Hubuwahnow?" Alice sputtered, trying to regain her composure.

"It's a surprise party," Mary said, stepping forward. "Hence us yelling surprise. You know, for your birthday."

"I... um... wait, how did you know it was my birthday?"

"Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport told us," Mary replied. "They actually helped us organize the whole thing."

"That's suspiciously nice of them," Alice remarked.

"Nah, they're actually pretty good guys," Vince chimed in. "Otherwise we wouldn't have known about your special day, since someone didn't bother to tell us."

"Oh, well, um, birthdays aren't such a big deal in my family. I guess it slipped my mind," Alice said lamely.

“Happens to the best of us,” Nick said. “Luckily for you, it certainly didn’t slip ours. Now, I hope you’re prepared for a night of collegiate celebration.”

Alice let out a smile she wouldn’t have believed possible earlier in the week.

“I think that might be okay.”

“Your words say okay, but your height says awesome,” Nick said.

“My what?”

Mary tugged on her sleeve and pointed down. Alice glanced at the floor and realized she was nearly a foot above it. With as much grace as she could manage, Alice lowered herself back to a gravitationally compliant position.

“Old habits,” she said by way of explanation.

“At least we can always tell when you’re happy,” Hershel pointed out.

“She’s like a buoyancy mood ring,” Nick agreed.

For her own part, Alice just kept on grinning like an idiot. As for that questioning voice in the back of her head, it wasn’t entirely gone, of course; such things just don’t happen overnight.

It did shut the hell up for the evening, though. There was a certain amount of triumph in that fact alone.

## 113.

Alice was exhausted, but filled with the soft glow of genuine delight. She was sprawled on the couch in the common room, the last (wo)man standing from the night's festivities. And festive they had been.

It turned out the reason everyone was so busy this week was that they'd each been putting together things for her party. Vince had scoured cookbooks and local grocery stores in an effort to make a five-star dinner. He'd actually done pretty well too, starting with scallops, then rack of lamb, and finishing up with a tiramisu, all of which were Alice's favorites. She wasn't entirely sure how he'd worked that out, but then again she'd gone dining with Mary several times, so maybe the small girl just paid a lot of attention.

Mary had gone above and beyond, too. After dinner they'd gone to a section out in the forest that had been completely overhauled. There were stands, barriers, and even some small bunkers. Hershel had designed an entire paintball course and Mary had built it, all in the span of a week. Here they met up with Thomas, Will, Jill, Sasha, and Alex to participate in a paint-based battle that can only be described as truly epic. Turns out nine Supers in the woods make for quite a tournament. Alice still wasn't certain who had won, since after a certain point it seemed to degenerate more into a brawl than any regulated system of scoring. She just knew it had been fun.

After a return to Melbrook everyone showered, then had a slice of fudge cake Vince had somehow cobbled together when no one was looking. Songs were sung, candles were blown out, and more processed sugar was ingested. Eventually the others grew tired and headed off to their respective dorms, then her own dorm mates had begun succumbing to the demands of biology and gone to bed.

Alice had been too wired, even now as she sat alone in the common room she felt jazzed up. She'd be sleeping late tomorrow, no doubt, but that's what Saturdays were for. She readjusted her pose and a white envelope fell to the floor. Ah yes, she'd nearly forgotten. Hershel had given that to her before going to bed, emphasizing quite clearly that it was from Roy and Roy alone.

At the time she'd been hugging Mary goodnight, but now her curiosity was tickled. She slid a manicured nail beneath the envelope's lip, breaking the seal. Inside was a slip of paper with only a few lines written on it.

"Redeemable for one night of sex. –Roy Daniels"

Alice couldn't stop herself, she began laughing with her whole body. The best part was that she knew, in Roy's mind, this was probably a very thoughtful gift. That notion redoubled her chuckles. Finally the fits subsided down to giggles as she wiped a few tears from her eyes and carefully placed Roy's coupon back in the envelope.

"Still in the party spirit, I see."

Alice whipped her head around. Nick was standing by the boys' side door, holding a small book at his side and dressed in sweatpants and a t-shirt.

"I didn't hear you come in," Alice said.

"That tends to happen when your eyes are shut and your ears are ringing with laughter. Plus, I'm actually twenty percent ninja, so there's that too," Nick said. He walked over and sat down on the couch with her.

"Twenty percent? How does that work?"

"Oh, a great grandparent who was a full ninja and then an uncle who was a fifth or something. I've never been great with fractions, so who can tell."

"We all have our failings," Alice replied. "So why are you still awake?"

"Aside from the cackling emanating from the common room? I wanted to give you your present," Nick said.

"And here I assumed you being civil all night was my gift," Alice said.

"Nope, just happenstance. It's hard to be snarky when looking down the barrel of a gun stuffed with paint."

"I can see your point," Alice agreed.

"So, any guesses on what you're getting?"

"I wouldn't mind another night out with that guy I introduced to my dad. He was pretty enjoyable company," Alice said.

"Sorry, he was sort of conjured on the spot. I don't know if I could do that again even if I wanted to," Nick lied.

"Ah well," Alice said. "I suppose you'll do for now."

"So happy to hear it. Anyway, here," Nick said, handing her the book.

“Happy birthday.”

Alice opened the diminutive tome and saw a young blonde girl staring back at her. It took a few seconds before Alice realized why the girl seemed so familiar. She turned the page and found the same face staring up at her, a winning grin on its face and a trophy hoisted overhead. More pages, same girl, slowly growing into a more recognizable woman.

She didn’t speak, she literally couldn’t think of any words. Instead she simply looked up at Nick for explanation.

“You once told me you didn’t have many pictures of your mom. You’d be surprised how many times we all end in pictures on public record. Anyway, I know a guy who knows a guy who specializes in this sort of-Ooof!”

Nick’s sentence was cut off by Alice spearing him in the chest as she engulfed him in a hug. Her arms knit around him and squeezed, her head resting on his chest. She held him like that for some time before either spoke.

“Thank you.”

“My pleasure,” Nick said, quite honestly for once.

They stayed in place for a moment more before Nick disturbed the quiet peace.

“If you’re going to keep cuddling me like this then I demand either sex or dinner. I’ve got my principles as a man after all.”

Alice laughed and released her grip on him. “Sorry, I just got a little...”

“Don’t worry about it. I had a similar reaction when Ms. Pips gave me my book.”

“Your book?”

“Well, yeah. How do you think I know a guy who specializes in this sort of thing? I wanted to see my parents, too,” Nick explained.

“Of course, I... Sometimes I forget there’s a real guy behind the smart assery and sunglasses,” Alice said.

“Oh, he’s real all right. Real freaking tired. I’m off to bed, and if you’re smart you’ll do the same,” Nick said, rising from the couch.

“I’ll go to bed soon,” Alice assured him.



“Sure, sure,” Nick said. He walked over to the boys’ side and opened the door. “It’s your night, stay up as late you want. I hope you had a good birthday, though.”

“I did,” Alice said. Nick nodded and stepped through the door, leaving Alice alone once again. She flipped through the book some more, savoring each new image in every detail, right down to the sound of the pages flipping.

“I really did.”

## 114.

“Today,” Dean Blaine said as the class settled into their seats, “I want to talk about categorization.”

Dean Blaine began walking along the front of the classroom, stepping out of his usual center area.

“Controllers, generators, absorbers, healers, enchanters, shifters, speeders, teleporters, advanced minds, and illusionists,” Dean Blaine said, ticking off each term on his hands as he rattled them out. “And that’s just a few off the top of my head. The full list of all the classified types of Supers goes on for several pages and is constantly evolving. Just from that statement, what can you tell me about the nature of this categorization? Mr. Murray?”

Will’s head snapped up. He hadn’t raised his hand, nor had anyone else. Dean Blaine had called on him before even Stella had the chance to bark her answer.

“A cursory analysis would suggest that if we’re still adapting something as general as the categories for different Super types then it means we’re still in a state of discovery regarding them,” Will said.

“Very good, Mr. Murray,” Dean Blaine complimented. “Will is correct; we are still learning more and more about Supers every day. Not just how certain powers function, either, but learning more about the broad spectrum different abilities can fall under. That isn’t the whole story, though. Anyone else? Mr. Matthews, perhaps.”

A long, lean boy in the front row snapped to attention.

“I guess it implies that there is still active research ongoing in the field of Supers,” he ventured.

“True, but a restatement of Will’s previous conjecture. Please pay more attention, Terrance,” Dean Blaine told him. “Let me add this nugget to the discussion. Did anyone else know that until seven years ago, Mr. Murray’s ability was not actually recognized as a power? Show of hands.”

Will and Jill slowly put their hands up. The rest of the class’s remained down.

“Thank you, you may put them down now,” Dean Blaine said. “So until seven years ago, Mr. Murray would not have been considered for the HCP. He would have been classified human by all metrics of the time. Yet

here we are, seven years later, and he is doing exceptionally well, posting excellent marks on a consistent basis. So, what changed seven years ago that altered Mr. Murray from a mere human to a Super, and a Hero candidate at that?”

“Duh,” Stella said, voicing her opinion at last. “You already told us. Extreme technological genius was classified as a power.”

“I did, Miss Hawkins, I did indeed. But that’s merely what I said. I’m looking to see if anyone noticed what I told you. There’s a conclusion here that I want you to reach,” Dean Blaine said.

It was a soft, unfamiliar voice to most of the class that piped up at last.

“The labels don’t mean anything,” Camille said, barely breaking over a whisper.

“And why is that?” Dean Blaine probed.

“Because nothing significant really changed. Will can invent things that make him a candidate to be a Hero. That’s true whether you call him a Super or not. He’ll always have that capability.”

“That is correct, Camille,” Dean Blaine said. “No change in terminology can take away the actual talent Mr. Murray has, nor any of your abilities. There was a time when telepaths were all thought to be charlatans, and illusionists nothing more than skilled stage magicians. It’s only over time, as these respective groups have consistently demonstrated their abilities, that they have been reclassified. Which brings us to most important thing you need to know about categorization.”

It was Vince who raised his hand this time, and Dean Blaine gave him the nod.

“They’re reactionary. The terms, the categories, everything in that area is created in response to new Supers or Poweredreds showing up and changing what they thought they knew.”

“Very good, Vince,” Dean Blaine agreed. “And that is the heart of the matter. Some of you are classified as shifters, or healers, or absorbers, and while the terms are comforting in that they make us feel like someone higher up the chain knows what is going on, it is critical that you all recognize them for what they are: words. It is human nature to put words to things, to file and sort even the ineffable. We do this because it makes us feel like we can control that chaos.”

Dean Blaine stepped back into the center of the room and gazed at the faces of his charges.

“Chaos is not here to be controlled. It cannot and it will not bend to the will of something as fleeting as an ancillary term ascribed to it. You are not controllers, or teleporters, or even Supers. You are individual people with individual skills. Never forget that. And never, ever forget that the same can be said for anyone you face out in the field. Grouping is a lovely tool for paperwork and mental accounting. Assuming you know what a person is capable of because you know the general shape of his power is dangerous, though. Often it’s downright deadly.”

“Deadly?” Stella snickered.

“Yes, Miss Hawkins, deadly. Because seven years ago, if you had run across a predecessor of Mr. Murray who lacked his moral code committing a crime, you would have undoubtedly assumed him to nothing more than another frail, powerless human,” Dean Blaine said.

“Yeah,” Stella agreed.

“And when he pulled out a device capable of liquefying steel, then utilized it, what would you have thought of him then?”

“Well-”

“That is incorrect, Miss Hawkins. You would have thought nothing, because, with all due respect to everyone’s individual beliefs about the afterlife, dead people do not think.”

“Okay, fine, but obviously someone realized Will has a real ability and took notice of it,” Stella said. “So that’s a bad example.”

Dean Blaine raised an eyebrow. “Yes, Miss Hawkins, ‘someone’ took notice. I want you all to think about something, though. Which seems more likely: that there was a long certification process through which ample evidence and documentation was provided, making the case for technological brilliance to be considered a power, or that a scenario very similar to the one I just described occurred and a Hero’s corpse was all the proof that was needed?”

“Oh,” Stella said, sliding down a few inches in her chair.

“Yes. Oh.” Dean Blaine realized he’d been addressing Stella directly and turned back to the rest of the class. “Please remember, a story like that is applicable to almost all of your powers.”

Some of the more astute students noticed a sliver of sadness in his voice at his next words. Luckily, they were also astute enough to gather the reason and keep it to their damn selves.

"So keep your wits about you, and never make assumptions. Because I'd very much prefer it if the next power to be added to the list was done so through the boring paperwork route. It would be a very welcome change of pace."

## 115.

Sasha's lips pressed firmly against Vince's neck, slowly trailing down to his collar bone. She kissed that more delicately, then gently nipped a bit of the skin between her teeth. The first time she'd tried this trick things had gone poorly, but Sasha was an older, more practiced girl now.

Her hands worked her way under his shirt, her nails slowly etching their way up his back. He'd always been lean, but with each month the body she touched was growing stronger and more muscular. He'd been cute when they first met; now the boy was bordering on hot.

She reversed the direction of her hands, circling around and leaving scratches down his front. She paused when she reached his belt line and took a moment to lightly run a finger across the implied border. She ran her left hand from one hip to the other, marking the line in the skin, then she pressed onwards, downwards. Her thumb popped the button on his pants before Vince reacted.

"That's okay," he said, taking her adventurous digits and clasping them caringly in his own conservative ones. "I'm fine with just kissing."

Sasha sighed and sat back. They were on the couch in her common room, making out yet again at the end of one of their dates. Most of the other girls were off having fun (naked fun at that, Sasha knew all too well), so she and Vince were free to pursue their hanky-panky right here in the open. Unfortunately, it was, once more, turning out to be all hanky and no panty.

"I know you're fine with just kissing," Sasha said, exasperation settling in and making itself quite at home in her voice. "You've been fine with just kissing me, your girlfriend, for months now. And while I appreciate the gentlemanly care that entails, I have to tell you, I'm starting to wonder if there's something bigger here. I mean, you find me attractive, right?"

Sasha leaned forward a bit at the word "attractive," treating Vince to a panoramic view down the front of her low-cut shirt. She was wearing tight denim shorts as well, and (although Vince didn't know it) lingerie designed to plump and pull in all the right directions. She'd put in a lot of work to look sexy tonight, in the exceptionally frustrating exercise of trying to seduce her own boyfriend, and it had paid off. She was beautiful in a way that conveyed accessibility rather than intimidation.

Vince swallowed. "You're gorgeous. I find you incredibly attractive. That's not it."

“Then what is it? I know you don’t want to push me or anything, but in case you’ve missed the signals, you aren’t pushing anything. I’m ready. I have been in a continual state of readiness for some time now, so where are we hitting the snag?”

“I’m not,” Vince said.

“You’re not what?”

“Not ready,” Vince took a breath and glanced away from Sasha, trying to get some of his blood flowing in the proper directions.

“You’re eighteen and male. A sweet male, but yeah, pretty sure there’s a biological mandate that you guys are always ready at this age,” Sasha pointed out. “So if you aren’t then I’m guessing there’s a deeper reason than just being nervous about your first time.”

Vince thought very carefully before his next answer. He’d never lied to Sasha about this, or even hinted in that direction. He had noticed that she’d never asked him the question, though, and somewhere along the line he suspected the assumption she’d made. That was going to make this awkward, but he’d made that choice of non-action and now he had to face the consequences for it.

“It wouldn’t be my first time,” Vince admitted. “I’m not a virgin.”

Sasha’s eyes widened. “Wait, what?”

“I’m not a virgin,” Vince repeated.

“Look, I understand you might have messed around with a girl a little and accidentally finished, but that doesn’t count as losing your-”

“Sasha,” Vince said taking her hand. “I’ve had sex. Full on, real deal sex.”

“Wow... um... when? I mean, was it a girl you met in the program before me?”

“We met on the first day,” Vince reminded her. “And no, it’s no one here. It was years ago.”

“Years? How many years are we talking?” Sasha asked. “I mean, you’re eighteen now, so...”

“I was sixteen,” Vince told her.

\* \* \*

“Stop! Thief!”

Vince’s breath was ragged as he pounded through the dense forest. A rogue branch scratched at his face, but he didn’t so much as break stride. He needed to keep-

\* \* \*

“I was seventeen,” Sasha said, snapping Vince back to the moment at hand. “I guess we never really talked about it, but I mean, I figured you would assume after knowing me this long. And of course I assumed from the way you kept holding off that... anyway, I was wrong.”

“It’s my fault, too,” Vince said. “I thought you might be under that impression, and I didn’t correct you. That was wrong of me and I am so very, deeply sorry. I understand if you want me to leave.”

Sasha barked out a laugh, then subsided into a fit of giggles. “Wow,” she said once she regained her composure, “I can’t believe you sometimes. I mean, here I am wondering if this semi-secret means there’s some hidden darker side to you, and then you go and apologize because you thought I might have made a wrong guess about you and you didn’t immediately correct me.”

“But I really am sorry,” Vince repeated.

“I know you are, sweetie,” Sasha said, her posture relaxing. “That’s part of what makes you so you. It’s not your fault I assumed you were a virgin. If I wanted to know, I should have just asked. You wouldn’t have lied to me.”

“Of course not,” Vince said.

“Of course not,” Sasha echoed, leaning in and kissing him. This wasn’t a kiss like earlier, meant to seduce. This was one driven by so much emotional connection that it burst forth and had to manifest in a physical form. This was her kissing him because in that moment she simply had to. It was as unstoppable as an airborne object’s eventual descent.

They eventually parted but their faces stayed close, almost touching yet not quite, as they picked up their conversation.

“So, if you’ve already lost it, and you keep putting me off, and it’s not because I’m unattractive to you, then I can only guess that the first time didn’t go so hot,” Sasha speculated.

“It was fine during,” Vince said. “It was the after that was problematic.”



“That can happen,” she said. “And you’re not ready to try it again?”

“If it matters that much to you, then maybe I can-”

“No.” This time it was Sasha’s turn to cut off Vince. “You wouldn’t ask me to do something I wasn’t ready for to make you happy, I’m not going to do that to you. Take your time. I’ll be here when you’re ready.”

“Thank you.”

“No problem, cutie,” Sasha assured him. “That said, when you are ready, I expect to be told immediately. I don’t care if we’re knocking people senseless in the middle of gym and a rogue blow puts it in your head. Immediately. No delays. Zip. Deal?”

Vince laughed. “Deal.”

“Good,” Sasha said, kissing him lightly once more. “For now, though, let’s go hit the video store.”

## 116.

In the course of any given year, there are certain periods which elicit expectation in their arrival among different demographics. In most of America the season of football is met with widespread anticipation. In Seattle there is a constant hope for a period called “two days in a row when it doesn’t fucking rain.” The deeper south looks forward year-round to its three days of winter or “Christmas” when they are able to wear long-sleeved shirts and pants without bursting into sweaty messes. Some seasons, however, are enjoyed less by a geographical demographic and more by a gender-based one.

“God I love mini-skirt season,” Alex said as he, Hershel, and Vince trekked their way across campus to the cafeteria. His comment was sparked by the bevy of co-eds currently crossing their paths, many of whom were employing the aforementioned fashion device.

“Pretty sure they call that ‘spring’ nowadays,” Vince said.

“‘They’ can call it what they want,” Alex replied. “I know what I look forward to, and it is not the increase in heat.”

Despite debate about its proper term, spring had undoubtedly sprung. Gone at last were the occasional snow flurries, the chilling wind, and desolate landscape. In their place was a bounty of foliage and endless warming sunshine.

“Call it whatever,” Hershel chimed in. “I’m just glad I don’t have to wear a jacket anymore. I’ve been ready for this ever since the beginning of Christmas break.”

“That far back?” Alex asked.

“Uhh, Chicago is really cold,” Hershel said lamely. In truth it had been their trip up the mountain that had soured him on winter weather, but he could hardly explain that to Alex without going into why the Melbrook students had an extra mid-term. That was a conversation Hershel hoped to put off until an appropriate time. Like, say, on his death bed.

“So I’ve heard,” Alex said, not sounding too convinced. “But who cares, it’s over now. And just in time for spring break!” Alex actually yelled the last two words, leaping up and punching the air. On a coolness scale of one to ten, it looked ridiculous. None the less, there were other calls of “Spring Break!” and some generic “Wooos!” that met Alex’s enthusiastic outcry.

“Plus we get the best spring break out of anyone,” Alex said. “Next week at this time we’ll be floating down the river, surrounded by friends and girls in swimsuits and with no fear about getting busted if someone sees us using our talents. It will be heaven.”

“I’m not sure how some people would feel about heaven including young women in skimpy clothing, but I see where you’re going,” Vince said. “And it will be fun to get away from it all for a while.”

“Glad you finally got on board,” Alex said. “How about you, Hershel? Excited?”

“What, are you joking? That trip is going to be all Roy,” Hershel said. “He’s been excited about it since January, and it is definitely more his scene than mine.”

“Aw, that sucks,” Alex said. “You don’t even want to hang out for a while?”

“Nope,” Hershel said. “Roy’s been pretty accommodating about letting me have some weekend time to spend with Mary. I owe him this.”

“I guess I can see your point,” Alex admitted. “Still won’t be as fun without you. I’m sure Mary will feel the same.”

“I doubt it,” Hershel replied. “She isn’t going.”

“Seriously?”

“Have you met her? Yeah, the wild drunken river trip isn’t her idea of a good time,” Hershel said.

“Wait, people are staying?” Vince asked.

“Don’t even think about it,” Alex snapped. “If Hershel’s not going to be there then you have no way out. Besides, we both know how much Sasha is looking forward to it.”

“I almost forgot that,” Vince said. He shrugged his shoulders. “Oh well, I already signed up anyway, and I’m sure it will be plenty of fun.”

“That’s better,” Alex said. “So Hershel is out, Mary is out, any other friends skipping the class trip?”

“Not that I know of,” Hershel said. “Nick and Alice are both gung-ho.”

“Same for Will, Jill, Thomas, and his friends,” Vince added.

“Good good,” Alex said. “Then we can still have an awesome time.”

“That is the goal,” Hershel agreed. “Any word on who they got to chaperone us yet?”

“Not sure who it will be, but someone told me they always get the top-ranked people from sophomore year to fill the role. It’s a reward to them since they get to spend their time on a free trip, and it lets us know from go that these are chaperones we can’t mess with,” Alex said.

“Some of the top-ranked sophomores, huh? I wonder if it will be anyone we’ve met,” Vince said.

“I doubt it,” Alex replied. “I mean, the only ones we really talked to were the beer-pong douches, and I’m not thinking either of them qualifies as a heavy hitter.”

“People can surprise you,” Vince said. “Besides, you’re forgetting someone. The hostess.”

“Oh yeah,” Alex said. “Man, she did have some badass mojo about her. Sort of cute, too, in a scary way. I don’t remember her name, though.”

“I do,” Vince said. “It was-”

\* \* \*

“Angela,” Shane DeSoto mumbled as he neared the blonde girl in the hallway. He gave her a brief nod and hoped she would continue walking. He was not so lucky.

“Shane,” she replied. “Have you heard the news?” She pulled herself to stop, and he was expected to do the same. He complied. They were in their HCP uniforms, walking along the corridors below campus. He’d just wanted to squeeze in some quick training. Of course he’d run into her, though. It was that kind of a day.

“I have not,” he said stiffly.

“It looks like they selected Ben and me to supervise the freshman river trip this year,” she said.

“I expected as much,” Shane said. “You are the number one in your class, after all. That’s why I don’t plan on going.”

“Don’t be silly, your name was on the sign-up sheet,” Angela said.

“I must inform you that you are mistaken. I certainly did not sign up

for this trip.”

“And yet your name is on the sheet all the same. I suspect you’ll have to buck up and have some fun anyway,” Angela said.

Shane stared at her. Of course she had put his name on the sheet. She undoubtedly had some other plan should he try to cancel his place as well. Likely several others for different contingencies.

“Why is it mandatory I attend?”

“Because it’s one of the best parts of being a freshman. One of the few good ones, actually. Plus it is tons of fun, and I think you could use that,” Angela explained.

“There is training to do,” Shane countered.

“With whom? Nearly everyone worth fighting will be on the river. Even your sparring buddy Chad signed up,” Angela said.

“Did he sign up, or is his name on the sheet?”

“Does it matter?”

“Yes. You might find him less receptive to your machinations than I am,” Shane pointed out.

“Nope, he agreed to go willingly,” Angela said. “I just had to motivate him.”

“Threats?”

“Promised I would give him a match if he went.”

“Ah,” Shane said. “That would do it. I suppose you have me over a barrel then.”

“I always do,” Angela replied. “Try to just go with it and enjoy yourself.”

“I’ll do my best.”

“Uh huh. I’ll believe it when I see it,” Angela said.

“That is probably the best strategy.”

Angela patted him on the shoulder. “That much I already know.”

“Was there anything else?” Shane asked.

“Just that.”

“So I can go now?”

Angela waved him off. “Go, train, be boring. But come next weekend you better be prepared for some relaxation, little brother.”

“I’m bigger than you,” Shane replied instinctively.

“But not better,” she countered with a wicked grin. “Remember, fun is not the enemy.” With that she sauntered off toward her own class.

Shane continued drudging forward, a foul mood descending over him. If he was losing spring break that meant he needed to work extra hard this week. It was all well and good to preach the benefits of having fun and enjoying oneself, but those speeches could only be made by the one standing at the top of hill.

Shane looked dearly forward to tossing down a few himself.

Eventually.

## 117.

“So come on, be brutal,” Alice said, turning around slowly.

“Honest opinion?” Mary asked.

“Absolutely.”

“It seems to show an awful lot of skin,” Mary replied.

“That’s the point. But does it cross the line between ‘Look at this hot body’ skin and ‘I have no self-respect and gain all my sense of value through your ogling stares’ skin?”

“You might be leaning a little bit toward the latter,” Mary said.

“Hmm, I’ll put it in the maybe pile then,” Alice said. She stepped into her bathroom and shut the door. A moment later she emerged in sweat pants and a t-shirt with a small amount of pink fabric between her hands. “Next I’ll try the green one.”

It was the night before the river trip, and Alice had more or less (more) bullied Mary into helping her choose some appropriate swimwear. It was far from the way Mary wanted to spend her first night of vacation, but she knew Alice was feeling a bit insecure about being the only girl from their group going on the trip.

“I still can’t believe you’re skipping this,” Alice said as she rifled through her dresser. “It’s going to be the event of the year.”

“I’ll hear all about it secondhand,” Mary said. “I’m sure people’s heads will be swimming with memories of this for weeks to come. As for actually experiencing it, I think I would enjoy that significantly less.”

“I know, I know. The party thing isn’t your scene. Still, it won’t be as much fun without you.”

Mary laughed. “I sincerely doubt many people will notice my absence. In fact, if the levels of alcohol provided are anywhere close to what I’ve heard, I doubt they’ll notice much of anything.”

“I don’t think it will be that bad. I mean, it’s not like most of us have much practice drinking. My money says everyone talks a big game and then only has, like, a beer each,” Alice said.

To this Mary could only nod. It would have taken her far too long to

explain to Alice the extent to which hormone-driven youths in scanty clothing would leap upon as effective a social lubricant as alcohol. So instead she changed the subject.

“This seems like an awful lot of effort just to decided what swimsuit to wear while floating motionless in a tube,” Mary pointed out. “Someone specific you’re hoping to impress?”

“Don’t be silly,” Alice lied. Out of courtesy Mary pretended not to be aware of the man who dashed through her mind at that question. “It’s just our first time in a really relaxed, social setting. You never know who you might hit it off with.”

“I see, you’re trying to look good just in case you strike up an enjoyable connection with a boy,” Mary said.

“I was looking at it more as chumming the waters and seeing who comes for a bite, but your version sounds much nicer,” Alice said.

“Yours does have an almost predatory tinge to it,” Mary said.

“Maybe mine was better, then,” Alice chuckled. “Still can’t believe you’re not at least curious to see all the boys in their swim trunks. Don't you want to see who’s a hottie and who’s a nottie?”

“I have faith I will receive a diligent report on that information once you have returned,” Mary said.

“That is an excellent point,” Alice yielded. “Aha!”

Alice’s hands emerged victorious from the dresser with a swath of dark green fabric. She promptly walked back into the bathroom and shut the door. She stepped back out a few minutes later.

“So?” Alice asked tentatively.

“You look like you’re one fast movement away from tumbling out of it,” Mary assessed quite accurately.

“Really?”

“The adjective I think best describes it is ‘bursting,’” Mary said.

Alice looked down at herself. “Bursting, huh? I can work with that. Another for the maybe pile.”

\* \* \*



“All right boys, from the top,” Nick announced. “Swimsuits?”

“Check,” said Hershel, glancing in his bag for visual confirmation.

“Check,” Vince echoed.

“Towels?” Nick asked.

“Check,” Hershel and Vince popped off in unison.

“Sunscreen?”

“Check,” Vince said.

“Roy doesn’t really burn, so I didn’t bother picking any up. Plus he likes to tan,” Hershel said.

“Fair enough, power-based immunity invalidates need,” Nick judged. “Flip-flops?”

“Check,” Vince said.

“In multiple styles,” Hershel added.

“Good stuff,” Nick said. “Novelty beer drinking helmets?”

“Check,” Hershel said.

“Yeah, it’s in there, but I still don’t see why I need to bring one when I don’t even drink,” Vince protested.

“Vince, your objections were heard, considered, and overruled earlier in the night. Let’s not revisit old business,” Nick said.

Vince looked over to Hershel for backup.

“In all fairness, they were,” Hershel pointed out.

“Fine,” Vince mumbled. “Check.”

“Good man. Sleeping bags?”

“Check,” Vince and Hershel sounded off together.

“Tents?”

“Check.”

“Flashlights?”

“Check.”

“Case of condoms?”

“Check,” Hershel snapped off in rhythm.

“Wait, what?” Vince yelped.

“Case of condoms. Come on Vince, try and keep up,” Nick chastised him.

“Why would I need condoms for a river trip? And why a case of them?”

“Vince, be logical. We’re spending a few days with beautiful, fit women who’ve had little outlet for all their pent-up frustrations over the course of the year. Add into that the remote setting, not to mention the tremendous amount of booze being bussed in, and can you really not imagine how it might be better to be prepared and have a condom than to make a mistake in the heat of the moment?” Nick asked him.

“I guess I can see some logic behind that,” Vince admitted. “But again, why a case?”

Nick shrugged. “Aim for the stars?”

Vince glanced over at Hershel.

“What? You think I’m arguing with him? Remember, I’m packing all this stuff for Roy. The last thing I want is to explain to people how my alter ego knocked someone up and that’s why I technically have a kid,” Hershel said. “I packed two cases, just in case.”

Vince sighed. “Okay, okay, points have been made. Let’s just keep going.”

“Fine by me,” Nick said. “Where was I? Ah, there we go, after the condoms. Insect spray?”

“Check.”

“First aid kits?”

“Check.”

“Chocolate-flavored body spread?”

“Oh come on!”

And so the night went.

## 118.

The parking lot was a celebration in itself. Freshmen were gathering here to obtain directions for driving out to the trip's starting point, then lingering around to greet friends as they joined the commotion. What began as a few cars stocked with students clutching maps soon escalated to nearly the entire first-year population of the HCP. Thankfully, most of them were carpooling; otherwise there never would have been enough room for everyone.

"I think that's everything," Vince said, surveying Nick's trunk.

"Your stuff, my stuff, Alice's stuff, Alex's stuff, and Will's sister's stuff?" Nick asked.

"Yup, we've got a full house," Vince confirmed.

"Also, my name is Jill," Jill added in.

"Just ignore him," Alice advised her. "He remembers, he just likes being difficult."

Jill shrugged. "Whatever. He's driving us all down, that makes up for a little annoyance."

"The day is young," Alice mumbled under her breath.

Vince turned away from the trunk and faced his girlfriend. "Sure you don't want to ride with us? We could have someone sit in a lap to make room."

"Thanks, but no thanks," Sasha replied, patting him on the chest. "I have, like, zero patience for sitting in cars. It bugs me to spend hours doing something I can do in minutes."

"It won't be as fun without you," Vince said.

"Damn straight it won't," she agreed. "I'll be waiting when you guys arrive, though. So drive fast."

"That's more up to Nick than me," Vince pointed out.

"I assure you, I'm properly motivated to make haste," Nick chimed in. "It's time spent cramped in my car on the highway versus time spent floating down a river with a cold drink in my hand."

"Hear, hear," Alex echoed.

“Sounds like the matter is well in hand,” Vince told Sasha.

“Then I’ll see you there,” Sasha said, planting a peck on his lips. There was a blur and a blast of wind and she was gone.

“I still think there’s a bit of room left,” Vince said after he’d recovered from Sasha’s speedy exit. “Jill, are you sure Will doesn’t want to come?”

“Positive,” Jill assured him. “That’s really not his scene. Besides, he says he has some project he wants to work on during the break. Trust me; my brother is way happier with his nose in a book than his body in a swimsuit.”

“To each his own,” Alex surmised. “I take it Her- I mean, Roy is making his own way there?”

“Took off on his motorcycle this morning,” Vince supplied. “Said he would have someone text him the directions when they were handed out.”

“At least he showed a little forethought in that regard,” Alice said. “I suppose progress is progress.”

“On that note, I suggest we ‘progress’ our butts into the car so we can get on the road,” Nick said. “I don’t know about you, but I’m not really feeling spending my day in the parking lot when there’s an aquatic option just a few hours down the road.”

\* \* \*

Roy fed his steel pony some gas and picked up the gallop. He was racing down the highway, sunglasses on his face, duffel bag slung across his back, and helmet nowhere to be seen. Sure, some cop might bust his balls, but one quick demonstration would show that in a battle between Roy and concrete, concrete was going to get its shit wrecked.

His phone vibrated on his side and Roy whipped it into view. It was a text from Julia letting him know the exact location they were starting at today, along with flowery language about looking forward to seeing him. He supposed he did owe her a good deep-dicking for sending him the directions. Plus, she wasn’t boring in bed, even after all these months. There was something to be said for that.

Fast as Roy was going (and to be honest, the speed limit was a distant arbitrary marker for him at this point), he was still utterly smoked a few moments later as something that registered as no more than a blur tore past him and kicked up a tremendous gust of wind.

Roy coughed on the dust that had been stirred up before choking out

the word “Bitch.” He pulled back harder on his throttle and ripped further past the speed limit, aware that he had zero chance of beating the girl who’d dashed past him and equally aware that he was going to try anyway.

\* \* \*

“I think we’re ready to go,” Dean Blaine said as the last of the freshman drove out of the parking lot.

“About time,” Angela said, walking over and stretching her back, resulting in a series of popping sounds. “You’d think when your choices are cruising the water and sitting in a parking lot people wouldn’t lag so much in the latter.”

“They were relaxing with their friends,” Ben pointed out. “We did the same last year.”

“Speak for yourself,” Angela countered. “By this time I was already three beers deep and topless.”

“There’s no way you were already on the river by this time last year,” Ben said.

“I don’t think I claimed I was,” Angela replied with a coy smile.

“Such a wonderful thing for the dean to hear about the female half of his chaperones,” Dean Blaine sighed.

“Look at it this way, I know all the stupid crap they’re likely to try,” Angela said.

“I suppose we’ll call that a silver lining and just breeze past it,” Dean Blaine said. “Now, you two remember how this works?”

“Sure,” Ben said. “We meet them at the start point, unload the river cruising gear, and pile all their stuff on the bus in its place. Then we give them tubes and outfit them with copious amounts of alcohol. One of the local staff drives the bus to the campsite and we cruise the river with them to make sure everything is okay. That night we camp and feed them. The next day is pretty much rinse and repeat, and so on until we come home.”

“Glad to hear at least one of you is up on procedure,” Dean Blaine said. “But I would appreciate it if you would at least go to the trouble of lying to me about the prescence of underage youths and alcohol. We try to look the other way during this trip so they can let loose from stress, but there are limits. Now, off you two go. We don’t want to make our students wait.”

“Psh, with all the tech this bus is outfitted with I bet we beat the super-speed kid there,” Angela said. “We’ll be fine.”

“Drive carefully,” Dean Blaine said, handing the blonde girl the keys. He watched warily as she hopped into the cab and fired up the engine, almost immediately stomping on the gas. Inwardly he wondered if it was such a good idea to choose chaperones purely by rank instead of by those with high levels of empathy and responsibility. Then he remembered some of the antics from his own trip so many years ago and resolved that it was better to have someone who was able to handle the big problems rather than someone with a talent for handling little ones.

He hoped.

## 119.

“Okay people, grab a tube, a cooler for those who want them, a few friends, and hit the water,” Angela yelled to the crowd. “We’re on the buddy system, so no one floats alone. Leave your crap in the bus. It’ll be waiting at the campsite when we finish today.”

“Don’t have to tell me twice,” Nick said, slinging off his duffel bag and tossing it into the rapidly accumulating pile by the bus. In its place he scooped up a bright yellow tube and a Styrofoam cooler. A cursory inspection showed it to be filled with ice, beer, box-wine bladders sans their boxes, and Jell-O shots. There also may have been a bottle of water or two, if there was room. Nick let out a low whistle. “Wow, they really do things right on these trips.”

Vince glanced over Nick’s shoulder. “Is that all for one person?”

“It is now,” Nick said, slipping the lid back on.

Alice grabbed a tube and a cooler as well, with Alex and Sasha following suit. Vince tried to stick with just the tube, however he was informed in no uncertain terms that he was getting a cooler too. They assured him that even if he didn’t drink the contents, someone would.

The group trekked down the worn dirt path, some admiring the forest around them, while other’s eyes were focused on the co-eds already splashing around in the river. They reached the edge of the water, running into Thomas, Stella, and Violet, who were already setting down their tubes. Thomas and Vince noted that each was carrying a cooler and exchanged knowing glances. It seemed those chosen to be mules for extra booze could recognize others of their kind. The crew from Nick’s car, as well as Sasha, placed their tubes delicately in the river and hooked the floating drink repositories to them using attached lines of rope. Then came the stripping.

It was a quick affair, one person from each group piling all the clothes into a cloth sack while another bagged the shoes. It was a matter of efficiency and quickness as most hurried to get water covering up these newly-exposed parts of their body. Some were less self-conscious than others, with Nick and Stella both moving slowly in disrobing down to their swimsuits, giving ample show to anyone who cared to watch. As Alice settled into her own tube, she was glad she had gone with the pink suit over the green one. Bursting was all well and good for show, but for a long day of relaxation she didn’t feel like worrying about things slipping out the whole time.

The group finished bagging the clothes and cast off from the shore,

joining the slow-moving convoy of fellow students drifting down the river. They were in their own clusters, with little more than a few tens of feet between each grouping.

“Now this is the life,” Alex said, plucking out a beer and cracking it open.

“A man after my own heart,” Nick said, pulling out a beer of his own.

The others, with the exceptions of Vince and Thomas, joined in as the current began pulling them forward.

\* \* \*

“Here at last, I see,” Angela said, handing tubes to Shane, Michael, and Chad.

“We took the scenic route,” Shane said.

“Did you now?” Angela looked over at Chad, who shook his head.

“He tried to hijack the car and steer us in a different direction,” Chad said. If it had been an interesting experience, one would never have guessed it from his tone.

“Ah, and what stopped him?” Angela asked.

“Me.” Chad took the tube and glanced down at the coolers. He reached into one and procured a lone bottle of water, then began heading toward the river. Michael, on the other hand, scooped up a cooler for himself, as well as the one Chad had poorly pilfered, and quickly began stepping after the blond leader.

“So, tried to run, huh?”

“I somehow find it difficult to believe you’re genuinely surprised,” Shane sighed, accepting a tube.

“I’m not surprised. More disappointed, really,” Angela said. She reached down and grabbed a cooler and held it out to her little brother. He stared at her, making no motion to accept it.

“So sorry to disappoint,” Shane said, turning away to follow his friends.

“Ahem.” Angela cleared her throat.

“Must we do this?”



“You’re going to enjoy yourself,” she declared.

“And the only way to achieve such a lofty goal is with the use of under-age drinking?” Shane asked.

“For you, probably. Otherwise you’ll spend the day moping in your tube, stuck on the fact that you were forced to be here rather than just enjoying how awesome this is,” Angela said.

“So your solution is to force me to do even more things I don’t want to?”

“In for a dime, in for a dollar,” Angela said, beaming a shameless smile.

Shane considered resisting, then surveyed his surroundings. It was still morning, and while the trees cast plenty of shadows, there was no denying the sun was out in full strength. Beating Angela would be hard enough if he had an environmental advantage. Without it, he was as good as wrecked.

Shane trudged back over and snapped the cooler out of Angela’s hands.

“Good boy, now catch up with your friends. We’re strict about the buddy system here,” Angela said.

“Then where’s yours?”

“Up ahead, minding the flock,” Angela said. “I insisted on waiting behind to make sure my dear little brother arrived safely.”

Shane’s eyes narrowed. “You know I’m going to beat you one day.”

“Maybe, maybe not. But unless you think that day is today I’d recommend getting your hustle on.”

Shane hesitated a moment longer, then took a brisk pace down the path after Michael and Chad.

Angela gave him a few minutes’ head start, then grabbed a tube and cooler for herself and began heading down. She began humming to herself, enjoying the sunshine and the beautiful day before her. She briefly wondered if today would be the day Shane earnestly tried to kill her. She doubted it; he was a strong kid, he could take a little more.

She’d be on guard, though, just in case.

## 120.

“Dare,” Stella said confidently.

“Fine, I dare you to shotgun a beer,” Violet challenged.

Stella dipped her hand into the cooler and produced a fresh can of low-proof alcohol. Her hand turned metallic as she slammed her index finger into the can’s side while popping open the top. Without coming up once for breath, Stella drained her drink and cast the can back into the cooler.

“See, this is why games played with your roommate are always more fun,” Stella declared, exchanging a high five with Violet.

“Your turn to pick someone,” Thomas reminded her.

“Oh, believe me, I’m aware,” Stella said, her voice bordering on predatory. “I’m looking at you, Nick. Truth or dare?”

“Truth,” Nick replied immediately. It was the obvious choice. Actions were undeniable; however, he could always lie with words.

“What in the hell is up with the glasses? I mean, seriously,” Stella said.

Nick took a draw from his own drink. He’d found that answering too quickly put up people’s defenses that it might be a deception. Going slow, however, and pretending as though the act of answering required alcohol-based fortification, those things sold the listeners on the legitimacy of an answer. Of course, it also helped to make it something that was either slightly revealing or embarrassing.

“They’re a social mechanism,” Nick said. “They keep me a little bit different, a little bit separated from everyone else. Back home I was so used to being special because of my powers, when I came up here I guess I was scared of blending in. So I made sure everyone would notice me.”

“Huh,” Stella said. “That was more honesty than I was expecting. Kudos, kid. Your turn.”

“I’m picking Vince,” Nick said. “Truth or dare?”

“Um, truth,” Vince said.

“Psh, that’s a waste,” Sasha chimed in. “Vince always tells the truth anyway.”

“A valid point, but how else am I going to get the boy to drink if I don’t try to catch him in a dare?” Nick pointed out.

“Fair enough,” Sasha conceded.

“Anyway, here’s my question for you, buddy. I noticed something odd when you took your shirt off. You have no scars, like, at all. Now, since you’ve been at Lander you’ve had healers on hand to patch you on the fly, but for a guy with your level of martial arts experience, it seems odd that you never sustained any injury. What’s the deal?” Nick asked.

“That’s a pretty invasive question,” Alice noted.

“I’m pretty set on making him pick dare next time,” Nick said. “So, Silver, how’s about it?”

“I used to have scars,” Vince said. “I got into an accident when I was sixteen, though. I was taken care of by a healer.”

“Oookay, so what happened all the injuries your body had sustained in the years prior?” Nick prodded.

“He was a very good healer,” Vince said, glancing away.

“Damn,” Stella said. “That’s an intense power.”

“No kidding,” Alex agreed.

“Question well answered, though I feel like there’s more story than I’m getting,” Nick said. “Your turn.”

“Hmm. I pick Jill. Truth or dare?”

“Dare!” Jill announced enthusiastically.

“Oh,” Vince said. “I suppose I dare you to put more sunscreen on your nose so you don’t burn.”

“Seriously?” Jill asked, her excitement deflating.

“Sure,” Vince said.

“Wow, okay you guys are awful at this game,” Jill sighed, pulling out her sunscreen and briskly reapplying to her face. “It’s not supposed to be these deep ass questions. It’s supposed to be embarrassing and at least vaguely sexual. For example, it’s now my turn and I pick Alice. Truth or dare?”

“After that lead in? I’m going with truth,” Alice said.

“Works for me. I’ve wanted to ask for a while anyway. Are those things fake or natural?”

Alice began blushing as soon as the meaning of Jill’s words registered. Still, she was playing the game, and that’s how these things went sometimes.

“Natural,” Alice said. “Apparently it runs in my family.

“Ugh, and with that tiny waist, too. You’re such a bitch,” Jill said, her tone full of more friendliness than her words.

“I do what I can,” Alice said, taking a drink from the chilled wine bladder that had been one of the features of her cooler. It was awful, awful stuff, made even worse if the consumer knew anything about wine. Her father would have died to see his daughter consuming such swill. Which might have been a significant factor in why Alice was chugging away on it.

“Okay, so my turn. I choose our tan stoic,” Alice said. “Thomas, truth or dare?”

“Truth,” Thomas said.

“Let’s see,” Alice said, drumming her fingers on the side of the tube. “Oh, I know! In terms of bases, just how far did you get with our little Violet back when you two dated?”

“I’m not sure that’s appropriate for a gentleman to disclose,” Thomas began.

“Oh, it’s fine, that’s the whole point of the game,” Violet interrupted. “Tell away, I’m not ashamed.”

“I believe the term is ‘Home,’” Thomas said, keeping his eyes firmly away from everyone else in the group.

There was a series of catcalls and whistling, as well as grumbling from Alex about even the ones who didn’t want it getting more play than him.

“That’s right, that’s right,” Violet said, lifting her arms in pride. “I nailed me a good boy. I know I’m your hero.”

“Moving on,” Thomas said. “I select Jill. Truth or dare?”

“Dare!” Jill said, once more yelping with enthusiasm.

“Very well, I dare you to lay a kiss on Alex that renders him incapable of coherent thought,” Thomas said.

“Woo, Thomas taking it up a notch,” Sasha cheered.

“She did advocate a more risqué theme in the game,” Thomas justified. “Besides, I find it permissible to look out for my friends.”

Jill began paddling over to Alex, who threw up his hands.

“There’s no need for that,” Alex said. “I’m not into girls kissing me out of obligation.”

“Oh, shut up,” Jill said as she reached him. She grabbed his tube and pulled herself close. Without pause she latched onto Alex’s shoulders and lifted her body up to his level. The kiss lasted for nearly a minute, long enough to become mildly uncomfortable for those watching. At last Jill released Alex’s narrow form and dropped back into her own tube, the force of her landing setting her drifting back toward Alice.

“I don’t know about coherent thought,” Jill said as she paddled to steady herself, “but I guarantee he won’t be able to stand without embarrassment for at least five minutes. That work?”

“That works,” Thomas confirmed. “Your turn.”

## 121.

If you'd asked Alex, he would have told you he was buzzed. If you'd asked someone with a bit more drinking experience, they would have told you he was past buzzed, nearing snockered, and well on the road to wasted. Regardless of his level of intoxication, though, he was happy and floating along.

He'd drifted away somewhat from his original group, but he was hardly concerned. There were students all around him, some still clustered, some floating freely as they found their concerns subdued by the rocking of the current and the chemical effects of alcohol.

Every now and then he caught sight of the chaperones, moving up and down through the crowds, keeping an eye to ensure everything was all right. For all their talk about the buddy system they seemed to content to let the free-floaters be, so long as they were at least in eye- and earshot of everyone else.

So lost in lack of thought was Alex that he didn't even notice he was coming up on another tube until he bumped softly into it.

"Whoops," Alex said. "Sorry."

"Eh, no worries," came a lilting, somewhat familiar voice.

Alex blinked and lifted his head, focusing on the inhabitant of the tube he'd just smacked into. She had long, dark hair and the bikini she wore exposed plenty of her caramel-colored skin.

"Hey. I know you. You're the chick that beat me and Vince in the finals," Alex declared.

The girl laughed lightly. "In fairness, I beat a lot of people in the finals."

"Oh yeah. You had the really pretty voice."

"Well, thank you. Always nice to meet a fan."

"Don't know if I'd call it that," Alex said. "But I respect the talent. I'm Alex, by the way."

"Selena," she said. "You're the other telekinetic, right?"

"For the love of... fuck it. Sure, why not?" Alex said, a measure of

defeat in his voice.

“Did I say something offensive?” Selena asked.

“No, no. Not your fault. Forget it. Let’s focus on you instead. What exactly is your power?”

“You mean my merry harmonies don’t qualify?”

“You had a pretty voice,” Alex admitted. “Not pretty enough to make us just up and lose without a fight, though.”

“I’ve had better compliments, but I’ll take it,” Selena said. “The truth is I’m classified as an enchanter. I cause certain effects in people when I sing.”

“Like making everyone who hears it your love slave?” Alex asked.

“That’s one example, yes. It’s one of my more limited techniques, however. To influence someone that profoundly requires constant stimulus,” Selena said.

“You, uh, you sort of lost me there,” Alex said.

“Sorry, how can I put this? A person’s mind is resilient. It tends to buck against outside influences. So to take you over like I did in the finals, I had to keep singing the whole time. If I’d stopped you would have come back to your senses pretty quickly,” Selena explained.

“There’s another option?” Alex asked.

“Sure. I can influence people in more subtle ways. Ways that don’t throw up the same mental red flags and can persist even after my voice stops.”

“Huh. Don’t suppose you could provide an example?”

“I can do better than that,” Selena said. She tilted back her head and took a deep breath. What next emerged from her was a throaty, fast-paced melody. It emanated outward, rippling through the air and into the ear drums of those on the river. As it spread, so did a wave of calm. Backs unstraightened, knotted muscles began to loosen, and worries slipped out of minds, splashing abandoned into the water below.

As the last of Selena’s notes faded, she lowered her head and looked back at Alex.

“So what did that do?” Alex asked.

“I helped people chill out a little,” Selena explained. “Made them feel happy and more at ease with the world.”

“I see,” Alex said. “Any potential side effects from messing with their heads like that?”

“Nah,” Selena assured him. “I didn’t do anything bad, just made them all feel a little bit better. I mean, worst case scenario, some people’s inhibitions might go down a bit, but that’s just a side effect of feeling good. You tend to worry less.”

Alex barked out a laugh. “So you make people feel relaxed and possibly lower inhibitions. You’re like alcohol without the liver disease!”

Selena’s well-featured face creased with concern. “Oh yeah... everyone is drinking, aren’t they?”

“Not everyone,” Alex said. “But a lot of us.” To prove the point he produced his beer and downed another swig.

Selena bit gently on her lower lip. “I forgot about that.”

“Why does it matter?”

“It probably doesn’t,” Selena said, though which of them she was trying to assure was up for debate. “It’s just that alcohol has a significant effect on the brain chemistry, and what I did will have an effect for at least a few more hours. And sometimes two separate influences can... compound on one another.”

“So people will be super relaxed and happy. Doesn’t sound like such a bad thing,” Alex said.

“Yeah... yeah, I’m sure you’re right,” Selena said. She reached over into her own cooler and produced a beer. Normally she wasn’t much of a drinker, but suddenly she found a strong craving for something to settle her nerves. Pity her own ability didn’t work on her.

“Wow, you worry too much,” Alex said. “I can feel your stress from here. Chill out a little, pretty lady. It’s the river trip!”

She stared at Alex for a moment. She’d nearly forgotten he was also a telepath. The only one here since the short girl had skipped. That might come in handy. If people got unbalanced he should at least be able to provide some sort of a heads up. Selena made a mental resolution not to let this boy out of her sight until she was certain there wasn’t going to be any trouble.



It would be fine, though. She'd only used a little bit of power, and people certainly hadn't had all that much to drink. Besides, she'd just sung them into a more peaceful, happier frame of mind. There was no way that could backfire.

Probably.

## 122.

Mary snapped her book shut with a sigh. Everyone had been gone since the morning and she was finding herself uncharacteristically bored. Sure, she was used to being alone, but the thing about living in the woods as a teenager was that there was always something to do. Wood to chop, food to hunt, water to gather, even traps to set. On a college campus, life was much easier. That was a good thing most of the time, but on days like this it was a solid pain in the butt.

Mary was in the library, the one under Lander's surface accessible only to those in the HCP, reading up on some historical Supers. At least, that had been her plan. Unfortunately, only a few minutes into the book and the words began slipping around the page, freed from their positions by the reality-shifting power of her boredom. Or at least that's what it felt like. Admittedly, she could have had Mr. Transport pop her home just as easily as to the library, but her parents were swinging by tomorrow to grab her for a spring road trip and she doubted they wanted to be disturbed a day early. They were big on taking time out to keep the romance in their marriage alive. Which left her a day to kill.

Mary noticed some movement from the corner of her eye. When she turned and faced the source she fleetingly wondered if she really had gone insane. Standing on the side of the table, waving for her attention, was a small orange paper cutout of a human shape. From the size and color Mary guessed it had been made from a sticky-note, and from the way it was jumping around trying to grab her attention she assumed that sticky-note had come from an ancient tome of great and unspeakable power.

The paper man seemed to realize she was looking at him, because he pointed his arm at her, then toward the rows of books off to the left.

"You want me to go into the stacks?" Mary asked it. She was taking it pretty well, but then again, when you're a telepath in a school for people who bend (and occasionally break) the rules of matter and physics, your threshold for weird tends to be higher than most.

The paper man nodded his head, then began scampering over on all fours towards her. It wasn't particularly dignified; however, it was more efficient than trying to balance on a pair of two-dimensional feet. He reached her side of the table in seconds and pulled himself back to a standing position. He pointed once more, this time at the hand she had resting on the table.

“What?” There’s nothing in it,” Mary said, holding her palm face-up to prove the point. In a flash the paper man had scampered into her upturned hand and perched himself there. Once situated, he pointed toward the same area of the stacks once more.

“I see; you still want me to go, you just want to come with me.”

The paper man nodded and gestured once more. Mary stared at him a bit longer, then shrugged and got up from her seat. Sure, this was eyes-meltingly weird, but it wasn’t boring. That was enough to keep her entertained for now.

They entered the stacks on the row her guide had indicated. She began walking down them, eyes alert for anything out of the ordinary. They’d only gone down a few rows when the paper man patted her hand and pointed her to the right.

Mary made sure she had the correct row, then turned and kept advancing forward. They went on like this for a few minutes, the paper man leading her deeper into the twists and turns that the library stacks offered. Mary was impressed at the sheer volume of books these different sections could hold. She hadn’t spent much time in the library, though that was likely to change after gaining firsthand knowledge of how comprehensive their collection was. The paper man pointed her down one last turn and the purpose of their adventure became abundantly clear.

“Hi there,” squeaked a girl hanging on the very top row of books by her fingers. “I don’t suppose you’d mind helping me down from up here?”

“Not at all,” Mary said. “You’re only about five feet off the ground, though; why not just let go?”

“I’m scared of heights,” the girl said. “I climbed up here to get a book, and then I made the mistake of looking down, and... I sort of freaked out and now I can’t look down to find my footing or let go and my hands are really starting to hurt.”

“Right,” Mary said. “Just close your eyes and try and relax your hands. I’ve got a good grip on you.”

“But you’re standing over... right, you’re the telepathic girl. Okay, okay; just give me second while I try to loosen my grip.” The dangling girl took a series of deep breaths. Mary wasn’t sure how long she’d been up there, though from the way her forearms were twitching it was clear she wouldn’t have been for much longer.

"I'm letting go," the girl announced. Mary pulled her away carefully, focusing on keeping the girl steady without squeezing too hard. Mary lowered her gently to the ground, the girl blasting out a groan of relief when her feet touched the floor.

"You're safe," Mary said. The girl wobbled at first, then leaned against the wall of books as she got her bearings back.

"Thank you so so so so much," the girl said, her eyes still squeezed shut. "I just wanted a stupid book about the first animator and I've been stuck up there for twenty minutes."

"No problem," Mary said. "We freshmen have to stick together. You're Agatha, right?"

"Yeah," Agatha confirmed. "And you're Mary, the number one ranked girl."

"Eh, that was over half a year ago. I'm certain things will change when we get reevaluated," Mary deflected.

"That's not what everyone else thinks," Agatha said, her eyelids slowly parting.

"Thank you," Mary said. She noticed the paper man in her palm was pointing toward Agatha. Mary obliged by mentally air lifting him over to the still-recovering girl, depositing him on her shoulder.

"What is he, exactly?" Mary asked.

"Oh, this little guy? Just an animation," Agatha said, picking up the paper guide. There was a small flash of turquoise and the paper hung limply in her hand. "There were some sticky-notes on the shelf. I juiced them up and sent them out to find help."

"I see," Mary said. "I've heard about that power. You can control inanimate objects, right?"

"Sort of," Agatha said. "It's more like I put a little piece of myself into them, my own energy if you will, and then they follow my commands."

"That's kind of cool," Mary observed.

"Yeah," Agatha agreed. "That's just the first level for animators, though. Those of us who are really good can sense the location of our objects, see and hear through them, even control them like an extension of our body rather than just as a henchman."

“Wow,” Mary said. “Can you do any of that?”

“The sensing, yes; the seeing and hearing, sort of. The extension part is still miles beyond me, though,” Agatha said. “Otherwise I would have juiced up the entire shelf and had it lean down to lower me to the ground.”

“You couldn’t give it an order to do that?”

“I could, but it might have interpreted ‘help me down’ as ‘collapse totally’ since that was that fastest way to comply,” Agatha explained. “Anyway, thank you again for the help. I’m going to go back to my dorm room and lie down until my hands stop shaking now.”

“Understandable,” Mary said. “Nice meeting you, Agatha.”

“You, too, Mary,” Agatha said. She headed off toward the exit, her steps still cautious, as though she expected to be swept into the air at any moment. Mary, for her part, turned her attention to the tomes surrounding her. Now that she knew about all the information here, it seemed her day might not end up so boring after all.

## 123.

The initial plan was for the tubes to be stacked up carefully in a designated area by the riverbank. That way they could be accounted for and easily dispersed the next day. Unfortunately, that plan failed to take into account the effect of several hours' drinking (and one Super's relaxation melody) on the mind of the average adolescent. The result was that as the Lander students emerged from the river at the designated point, a veritable clusterfuck of rubber tubes formed. They were tossed, dropped, or sometimes left to drift down the stream, forgotten entirely. Angela and Ben had prepared for this, having been contributors to the mess last year, and were managing to at least stop the ones breaking for freedom down the blue aquatic road.

As a result, they were of little help as the predominantly intoxicated teens began the arduous task of setting up their tents. Coupled with the fact that many of the students possessed very destructive capabilities, it was thanks only to the few who had remained sober that the campsite didn't wind up as a smoking crater in the ground.

"Okay," Vince said, wiping the sweat from his brow. He'd need to take a dip in the river again when this was all done just to feel clean. "I've got mine, Sasha's, and Alex's all done."

"I've completed tents for myself, Jill, Stella, Violet," Thomas replied. His power made the set up a much faster process since he could use his energy to grasp multiple tools simultaneously.

"Meanwhile, I've barely managed to put up my own and Alice's, thanks to her insistence on helping," Nick grunted from the ground where he was tying off a stake.

"You needed my help," Alice protested, her words clearly slurred. "You're drunk."

"Quite right; what would I have done without you tripping into the fabric, uprooting the entire structure and forcing me to start all over?" Nick said.

"Damn skippy," Alice said, crossing her arms.

"Besides, you're drunk. I've only managed to get a buzz since someone keeps stealing my beers," Nick said.

"At least we know where this one is," Vince said, pointing at Alice. "Has anyone seen the rest of the girls?"

"I've kept an eye on them," Thomas assured him. "They're over near the bus, milling with the rest of the group."

"That seems safe enough. And Alex?" Vince asked.

"Last I saw he was still hanging around that Selena girl," Thomas said.

"Good for him," Nick said. "That girl is hot with a capital sex."

"Pffft. That doesn't even make sense. And you can't say stuff like that, anyway. You're a bound man now, you and Bubbles keep going out together," Alice said. Normally she would have done a much better job keeping the spite out of her voice.

"Bubbles is great, but the day I stop appreciating the female form in all its splendor is the day they're laying me in the ground. And even then I'm not making any promises," Nick shot back, ignoring her tone.

"You're such a goddamned asshole." Alice swayed herself to a standing position and began wobbling off into the woods at a brisk pace.

The boys stood uncertain for a few seconds, trying to comprehend her reaction.

"Huh, I didn't think it was that bad," Nick said. "I figured at most she'd punch me in the arm."

"That did seem to be a bit of an overreaction," Vince agreed. "I mean, in comparison to the stuff you normally say, that was pretty tame."

"I think perhaps both of you missed the crux of that situation," Thomas said. "Regardless, she seems to be getting away from camp without slowing, so it might be a good idea to go after her."

"You guys have fun with that," Nick said. "If I chase her down today I'll be filling out a domestic abuse complaint tomorrow. Not sure why she only hits me."

"You do the most to provoke it," Vince said. "But that's fine; you get some food working. It will be dark pretty soon and everyone will be hungry. Thomas and I will go make sure Alice is okay."

"Oh it is Fucking Go Time!" That declaration was launched in the audible tenor of Stella Hawkins, voice thick with aggression and fury, emanating from the collective area near the bus.

"Or we'll go find out what's going on before Stella seriously hurts

someone,” Thomas amended, immediately dashing over to the area.

“Crap, there are a lot of people milling around. This might be bad,” Vince noticed. “I should go help Thomas; Nick, do you mind?”

Nick was already on his feet, producing a flashlight and a compass from his bag. “No, I get it. If there’s a Super throwdown you and Thomas can help keep the peace. That means the ‘calm down the drunken princess’ mission falls to the guy without astounding powers.”

“Your powers are very astounding,” Vince told him. “Just not in this particular venue. I think they’re well-suited to your task, though. Talking down Alice will require a little bit of luck.”

“Saints preserve us,” Nick said. The two boys parted in separate directions, Nick heading north and Vince just over to the buses.

The crowd at the buses was thick and difficult to cut through. Their intoxication and fascination with any altercation made the situation even more troublesome. Thomas had handled this hurdle by conjuring a wedge out of orange energy and plowing right through. Vince, on the other hand, was left with slipping through slowly, apologizing as he went. Finally he made it to the front. The sight that met his eyes was one of Roy Daniels and Stella Hawkins, both a foot or so off the ground cocooned in a familiar orange glow. Thomas stood in the center, sweat beginning to materialize on his face. This had to be a heavy burden for him, especially as both captives struggled violently.

“You two... need to calm down,” Thomas said, his breath broken by effort. It wouldn’t have been so bad if Stella hadn’t shifted, but a girl made entirely of steel was considerably heavier than one made of flesh.

“Fuck that, put me down, Thomas!” Stella yelled.

“Let the lady come get her licking,” Roy agreed, flexing against his own bands.

The next voice that pierced the fray was neither of the three. It came from the back of the crowd and parted it like a 1950’s haircut.

“I agree, let them both down,” said Angela. She stepped forward effortlessly, a peaceful air surrounding her as she entered the chaotic fray. “They won’t be attacking one another until I find out what happened.”

“You... sure?” Thomas grunted.

A wide, gentle smile slid on Angela’s face.



“They will behave. That is a promise.”

## 124.

Nick clicked on his flashlight and grumbled to himself. The girl had been less than a minute ahead of him, yet he'd already lost sight of Alice. It wouldn't have been so bad if not for the quickly diminishing rays of sun and Nick's lack of wilderness knowledge. He'd had extensive training in so many areas, but not surprisingly, they'd skimmed a bit on what to do in the woods. For a syndicate in Vegas, it was assumed if you were getting dumped in the forest you were no longer in a position to navigate your way home, or anywhere else for that matter.

The trees were doing a marvelous job obscuring what little light was left, their long shadows and thick foliage darkening the path at every step. Nick was aware the farther he went, the harder it would be to find his way back, to the point where another search party might be formed to find him. Still, the fear of being hopelessly turned around in the woods was not at the forefront of worry on Nick Campbell's mind.

Something was wrong in his head. He couldn't put a finger on it, but he knew something was amiss. He'd watched his alcohol intake carefully, and over this amount of time he knew how he should be feeling: a slight mellow with no impairment of judgment. Instead he was feeling increasingly relaxed, despite the danger of his situation. There was something else ticking though his synapses, too. It was difficult to describe; however, if he had to take a guess, Nick would have called it giddiness. It was an unwelcome guest in his cranial space, yet the longer it remained, the harder it was to remember why he disliked it.

Something was amiss in his brain, and that fact terrified Nick Campbell far more than the dark forest he was presently getting lost in.

\* \* \*

Thomas carefully lowered the would-be combatants to the ground and released his energy grip. To their credit, neither dashed forward and began assaulting the other, though anyone looking at their eyes could see it was only a hair's breadth from happening. In this case the hair holding it back was the smiling blonde stepping between them.

"So, why don't you explain why you two were headed for blows?" Angela said calmly.

"I'm sick of his shit!" Stella yelled. "He was running his mouth again about how women have no place in the battlefield and I decided to shut it for

good.”

“To be fair, my exact words were ‘the only useful power for a woman is one that conjures up food or babies,’” Roy corrected. “And I was joking around. Someone must be leaking steel blood today.”

“I’ll show you blood,” Stella said, taking a step forward.

Angela whipped her head around and met Stella’s eyes. They stayed like that for only a moment before Stella pulled her foot back to its previous position.

“To make sure I understand, Roy made a misogynist comment about women being weak, and Stella opted to give him an objective lesson in the incorrectness of his assumptions. Right?” Angela asked.

“They also bickered for a while before it came to blows,” a random voice in the crowd volunteered.

“I’d assumed about as much,” Angela said. “Okay then, have at it.” She moved backward.

“Wait, what?” Thomas squawked.

“They’re having a legitimate disagreement, and neither of them is going to get seriously injured from duking it out. All I ask is that you take it in the woods so you don’t mess up the bus or anyone’s tents,” Angela said. “And by ask, I hope you can infer what I mean.”

They inferred quite well.

“Truce until we’re a few minutes out in the woods,” Roy proposed.

“Fine by me,” Stella agreed. “I can wait a bit to mess up those pretty boy looks.”

Roy snickered but began heading south into the forest. Stella followed suit a few steps behind. Silence fell upon the remaining students as the two fighters crossed the tree line and faded from view. Fortunately it was quickly broken by a cheery tone.

“Okey doke, folks, I think it’s time for roasting hot dogs,” Angela declared.

\* \* \*

Vince walked away from the crowd once he was certain the Roy and Stella situation was handled. He had to admit, Angela’s solution made sense.

They were both hard-headed and weren't likely to give up on the idea of fighting once it had been planted in their brains. That might have been fine if they weren't too strong to stop once they got going. No, the best course of action was to just have them work out their aggression at a safe distance from the campsite.

A part of Vince felt like he should have followed along, just to keep an eye on them. Another part felt that he should go after Nick and Alice to make sure they got back safely. The part that won, though, was the piece of Vince's brain that advocated jumping back in the river before either course of action. Putting up the tents had left him sweaty and stained with dirt. He decided he would take a quick dip to cool off, then see which of the situations was the most pressing.

Vince walked carefully out toward the river, enjoying the slight serenity of being at least close to alone on the forest path. There was still plenty of noise coming from the campsite, enough that Vince didn't notice the footsteps following his own. Instead he tried to block it all out and draw in deep breaths of clean air. He'd almost forgotten how much he enjoyed being outdoors on his own. Sleeping under the stars, cooking over an open fire, even rinsing off in a river were all little joys he'd once savored. Joys he was looking forward to indulging in again this weekend.

Vince reached the water's edge and splashed forward. He dove under a few times, letting the cool liquid soak his silver hair and run down his back. He waded back up to waist-deep level and turned to watch the sun dip down below the horizon. He took a deep breath and felt several knots of tension flow gently down the river. There was a light splash behind him, and this time Vince heard it. He would have turned around to investigate it too.

The only thing that stopped him was the pair of arms that snaked around his body, locking him in place and squeezing hard on his torso.

## 125.

Nick was lost. He'd come to terms with this fact several minutes ago, and was now in the recovery stage of dealing with such a realization. His first attempt was to retrace his steps back toward camp, however the sun had slipped away completely and Nick's tracking ability was already poor. His tracking ability by flashlight was at a level of failure on par with the combination of moonshine mixed with chocolate milk. Had Nick been in this predicament a year ago his only remaining recourse would have been to start a forest fire and hope someone came to investigate. This was not the Nick of a year ago, though, and he had another option available to him.

Nick stopped trying to find his way and focused his luck. He closed his eyes, spun around, and began walking in a random direction, using his flashlight to see, but making no attempts to track his course. Whichever way the trees seemed to break, that was the path he took. It was slow going, navigating the shrubbery in the night wearing only a swimsuit, sunglasses, and flip-flops, but step by step progress was made. Nick just wasn't sure about progress toward what.

That was the thing no one seemed to get about luck. In a confined sense it was very predictable, like a dice or card game. Under those circumstances there were defined outcomes that were positive and negative. Good luck yielded the good results, and vice versa. The larger the scale of the task, the more variables were present and the more potential outcomes were at hand. Good luck would yield a desirable outcome, of course, however that didn't guarantee it would be the one he wanted. He was hoping to find his way back to camp, but he could just as easily fall into an undiscovered gold mine, or get chased by a bear into the arms of a beautiful woman. Luck, even when you could control the direction it flowed, was unpredictable. That was why he so rarely used his power outside of tightly controlled circumstances.

As the sound of a familiar sniffing reached his ears, Nick let out a sigh. Once again Lady Fortune had heard his plea and then decided to do whatever she damn well pleased to him. Nothing to do but make the best of it.

"Alice," Nick called. "Are you okay?"

Her response came from higher than he'd expected. "Nick?"

"You got it," he said, waving his flashlight around so she could see him.

"It would be you," Alice muttered from the darkness. As Nick

squinted into the night he made out a bikini-clad shape slowly descending toward him. Alice floated down from the tree she'd been perched in and settled at his side.

"How you feeling, Drunky?" Nick asked.

"A little scared," Alice admitted. "And a lot lost. I didn't mean to walk so far, and then the sun set, and I wasn't sure what to do."

"Fifteen beers will do that," Nick said, patting her shoulder. "My bet says our friends have lit a fire to cook on by now. Why don't you float over the tree line and see which direction they're in?"

"Okay. That makes sense," Alice agreed. She flew carefully upward, trying to dodge tree branches with only a moderate success rate. Once she crested the tops she could feel the night wind lapping against her skin. It took only a moment to spot the orange glow of her camp. They were a little bit to the north, maybe a five minute walk away. Alice let out a sigh of relief and lowered herself back into the trees. She took a few more scratches as she flew toward the beacon of Nick's flashlight, however she ultimately reached the ground safely.

"Did you see it?" Nick asked.

"I sure did," Alice replied.

"Whew. Okay, Princess, you point the way and we can get out of these damn woods," Nick said.

Alice opened her mouth to tell him the appropriate direction, but before she could something else entirely leapt out.

"No."

"No?" Nick asked.

"No," Alice confirmed, her brain, boozy as it was, catching up to her mouth. "I have you trapped in the woods with information you need, and no audience. You and I are going to have a talk."

"A talk?"

"A talk," Alice repeated.

"Okay, what are we going to talk about?" Nick asked.

"You," she said.

“I guess that works. My favorite food is sushi, favorite color is gold, big fan of horror movies, fifteen inch penis, love long walks on the beach, just tell me when you’ve heard enough,” Nick rambled.

“No,” Alice said, waving him off. “I mean we’re going to talk about just what your damn problem is.”

“Wow, drunk Alice really doesn’t pull any punches,” Nick observed.

“Enough deflecting. I mean it. You act like this intolerable jackass with a never-ending stream of snarky comments and bad jokes. Then, with the flip of a switch, you can become this charming, knowledgeable, really sweet guy,” Alice said, her voice raising a few octaves. “I mean, what the fuck?”

“Intolerable jackass, you sure know how to sweet talk,” Nick spat back. “I explained before, the thing with your dad was just an act. I pulled together some crap I saw from movies about high society and did my best. I’m glad it worked, that doesn’t mean there’s some super deceptive side to me, though.”

“I don’t believe you!” Alice’s voice crescendoed higher, passing the line of stern talking and entering the realm of the yell. “I know there’s more to you than that. Yes, that was the first time I saw it but I’m not blind, Nick. I’ve been watching since then, and I keep seeing little snippets of that guy. You can lie all you want, but I’m done being a sucker. I know there’s more to you than this.”

Nick took a deep breath and steadied himself. He could feel that strange tickle in his brain still, clouding his judgment. Still only slightly, but it was growing stronger. He needed to end this discussion, quickly. Unfortunately, for Alice, that meant going for the throat.

“Alice, I’m sorry,” Nick said.

“So you finally admit it?”

“No,” Nick said. “I’m saying that I’m sorry you have a crush on the guy I pretended to be. That wasn’t what I meant to happen, and I hope you know that.”

“You think I have a crush on you?”

Nick shook his head. “No, not on me. On who I pretended to be to impress your dad. You obviously liked him. That’s why you think you keep seeing glimpses of him in me. That’s why you’ve developed this radical idea that I’ve been faking who I am the entire year instead of just that evening. I

mean, really think about it Alice, which seems more likely?"

Alice stared at him, her wide eyes gleaming in the glow of the flashlight. "You... you're lying. You're lying again."

"I wish I was, Alice. Things would be a lot easier. But the truth is that you got enamored with a fictional character."

"That's bullshit, Nick, I'm not falling for this!"

"Falling for what? The fact that you only like a version of me you saw for a few hours at a dinner, a dinner where you knew I was lying the whole time? Or facing the fact that the lie version of me is the only version of me you've ever been attracted to, a fact I'm trying really hard not to let hurt my feelings, by the way."

"Why would that hurt your feelings?"

"I don't know, maybe because someone I've spent an half a year living alongside, who knows what it's like to grow up with the same defect, and climbed a fucking mountain with, had to invent a complex delusion just to find me the least bit bearable," Nick shot back, raising his own voice in turn. "You don't see how that might be the least bit shitty for me?"

"But... I know he's you," Alice said weakly. Nick smiled inwardly, her hesitation was the sign that he'd successfully sown doubt. He was home free now. All he had to do was wrap things up carefully and he would put both Alice's affections and suspicions to bed for good. And then, as Nick felt the genuine joy of a well-played altercation mingle with the giddiness from Serena's song, something slipped.

"Please, Alice, you don't even know the real me," Nick said. He slammed his mouth closed so hard that his teeth clicked. That hadn't been how he'd meant to phrase it. That said far, far more than he wanted to. Briefly, Nick hoped that in her still-addled state of mind Alice would miss the meaning in those words.

One glance in her eyes dispelled all traces of that dream, like a broom sweeping through cobwebs.

"I don't even know the real you," Alice said, some of the conviction returning to her voice.

"That's not what I meant," Nick said, backpedaling quickly.

"Now that, I believe," Alice said, a smirk twitching at the corners of her mouth. "Maybe you're right, Nick. Maybe I've been seeing that version of



you because I wanted to. And maybe he's as fake as you claim. That doesn't automatically make this version of you real, though."

"Alice, you're sounding deluded again."

Alice silenced Nick with a finger to his lips. "You just said something honest to me. Possibly one of the very few things that has crossed your lips and falls into that category. Please don't taint it by lying again already. Just give me a few minutes."

Nick looked at her green eyes. The jig wasn't necessarily up, but if he pushed her any harder on this it very well could be. It was more logical to wait, to let her sober up and hope she had poor drunken recall. And, if Nick were being brutally honest with himself, perhaps a part of him enjoyed someone looking at him and actually seeing even a piece of what was really there.

Nick simply nodded, unable to trust his tongue not to twist any words that might start with the best of intentions.

"Thank you," Alice said softly. "We can go back to camp now." She took his hand and began leading him north. Alice came to a halt after only a few steps, though.

"Oh, what the hell," Nick heard Alice say, and that was his only warning before a soft, warm body and a clumsy pair of lips crashed against his own.

Alice was an awkward kisser, but what she lacked in experience she was not missing in passion. Nick had spent the entire year trying hard not to notice just how shapely Alice was, and as she wrapped her body around him, his efforts came crashing down. He kissed her back, a flurry of resistance and indulgence as he warred with himself inside. At last, one part pulled ahead of the other and he pushed her back.

"Alice," he said carefully. "You're a beautiful girl, but this isn't right. You're intoxicated and I'm seeing someone. We shouldn't do this."

"I agree," Alice said, her voice steady but her breath panting. "That kiss wasn't for you tonight. It was for the real you."

"The kiss was for the real me?"

"Yup. In case I like him. Because I hope you know that I will meet him one day."

Nick forced out a laugh. "Whatever you say there, Drunky. Let's head

back to camp and get some food to sober you up.”

Alice let his comments pass and instead took his hand once more. She led him swiftly to the camp, though not so swiftly that she didn't get to savor leading him around for once.

## 126.

Vince reacted immediately, his mind racing to analyze the situation. He had no electricity and little fire in his arsenal at the moment, which meant he could flare up quickly and drive off the attacker but have nothing left for afterward. He was waist deep in water, so any fast movements to break the hold were going to be extra difficult to execute in the way of legwork. That left relying on a swift blow coupled with his flexibility.

Vince twisted his right elbow around with all the force he could muster, intent on driving it into the temple of his attacker. It would hurt his shoulder, but unless the assailant had enhanced durability, it would disorient them enough for Vince to slip free. That was the plan, anyway.

What actually happened was Vince's well-thought-out attack connected with nothing. All at once the arms holding him were gone and Vince was jerking through the water, knocked off balance by the momentum of his failed blow.

"Geez, somebody doesn't like surprise hugs," Sasha said from the shore. The wake dispersing through the water made it pretty clear just where she'd been standing when Vince was grabbed.

"I... sorry," Vince said, finding his footing in the water. "I thought you were attacking me."

Sasha tilted her head. "That's an interesting assumption to jump to. Got a reason to suspect someone might be out to harm you?"

Vince hadn't told her about Michael's Halloween attack, or the constant aggression the boy showed him at every turn. It just hadn't seemed like something she needed to worry about.

"Not really. Not today, anyway," Vince said. He hadn't had an altercation with Michael in months, so there really was no good reason for him to be so jumpy.

"Mmhmmm," Sasha said, walking back toward Vince at a slow pace. "You know, you're lucky your girlfriend has speedy reflexes or this would be really awkward right now."

Vince paled. He hadn't even thought about that. If he'd slugged Sasha he would feel absolutely abominable.

Sasha laughed. "Oh, relax, I'm kidding around. It was a good elbow,

but it wasn't a secret death shot. Worst case scenario I'd have a bump and some static in my vision for a few minutes." She reached Vince, the water coming up to her navel rather than waist. Vince was a few inches taller than she, and as she leaned against his chest, Sasha reflected for the umpteenth time how much she enjoyed that feature.

"There wouldn't have been words to say how sorry I was," Vince said, curling his arms around her.

"I know that, silly," Sasha assured him. "You're all about keeping the people you care about safe. And you do a great job of it. I never feel safer than when you're holding me tight."

\* \* \*

"Tights," she said, leaning over him. "What am I going to do with you?" As she moved her curly dark hair tumbled down, dangling only a few inches from his body.

"You could start by not calling me that," Vince suggested. His voice seemed to be caught somewhere in his throat, causing it to come out rougher and lower.

"I could, but I won't," she said. She smiled down at him, and for the first time the smile could be seen in her emerald eyes as well as on her face.

"Worth a shot," Vince said, retuning her grin from his own prone position.

\* \* \*

"Woo, this water is starting to cool down," Sasha said, breaking their embrace. "What's say we go get towed off and warmed up?"

"Why, Sasha Foster, are you asking me to put more clothes on?"

"I am, though if you have a better warming method I am quite open to suggestions," Sasha replied.

Vince pulled her back into his embrace and kissed her, running his hand through her hair and holding it tightly. He didn't pull, he just held her there, locking her lips and body against his own. He released a few seconds later, pulling his face mere inches away.

"That do it?" Vince asked. He'd mean to sound casual, making light of the intense kiss they'd just shared. His throat felt thicker than normal, and the voice that emerged from it sounded like someone had poured molasses on his

usual tenor.

Sasha didn't respond verbally. Instead she leapt up onto Vince's long frame and wrapped her legs around his waist, burying her lips against his. The movement would have knocked most men down, but then most men weren't undergoing daily physical training in the Lander HCP. The affection assault did rock him backwards, carrying him toward the shore opposite of the camp with the other students. Sasha fully expected to get another good kiss then be set down by her boyfriend as he reminded her that wasn't the type of relationship they had. He took her by surprise instead, scooping his arms under her to get a grip, then carrying her the rest of the way to the shore.

They came down at last, falling onto the soft ground a few feet away from the river's edge. They rolled even further inland, bit by bit, a constant rotation of top to bottom positioning as they tried to stay comfortable on wet grass. When they finally broke apart they were far enough from the water to have it obscured from view, but not so far that they couldn't hear its gentle lapping against the shore.

"Whoa," Sasha said, catching her breath. Her skin was tingling and her body was quite far from cold. She tried to steady her mind and her trembling hands. She'd promised to be a good girlfriend and wait for when Vince was ready. And she'd meant it, too: he was too good of a guy for her to trade his mental comfort for some fleeting physical fun. That being said, if he kissed her again there was a good chance she would tear off his swimsuit and tie him to a tree until he found his willingness.

"Yeah," Vince agreed. He felt like his whole body had been short-circuited somewhere along the line. Everything seemed sharp and enhanced; even the wind on his skin was noticeable. At the same time, his brain felt half-fried. All his thoughts seem to show up simultaneously then evaporate into silence.

"Sorry about that," Sasha said, pulling herself to a standing position. She wanted to rest her head on Vince's shoulder again; however, she didn't trust herself to touch him right now. Not even lovingly.

"No, no, it's my fault," Vince said, remaining in a sitting position for certain logistically-embarrassing reasons. "I started it."

Sasha left out a small chuckle. "Man, how sad is it that we have a crazy good make-out session and our first response is to apologize to each other for it?"

"Pretty sad," Vince agreed.

“So, let’s agree: no more of the ‘I’m sorry’ stuff. We’re boyfriend and girlfriend, we get to make out guilt free. That’s one of the many perks of being together,” Sasha said.

“Along with movie and dinner partners,” Vince pointed out.

“Not to mention someone to cuddle with,” Sasha said. “And of course, best of all is that we each get a great friend.”

“A very great friend,” Vince said.

“All right, then: nice, logical perks of being a platonic couple. This helping you calm down at all?”

“Not really,” Vince admitted.

“Me neither,” Sasha said. “But we’ll get there. Maybe the cold water will help.”

“You seem pretty determined.”

“Damn skippy,” Sasha said. “I want to be able to get kissy with my boyfriend, even if that means devising all sorts of self-control methods to stop it from going any further.”

“Or... we could let it go further,” Vince said.

Sasha’s skin froze and her blood turned to fire simultaneously.

“What are you trying to say, Vince?”

Vince brought himself to standing position, deciding eye contact was more important than modesty for a moment like this.

“I’m saying you’re my girlfriend, and I care a lot about you, and I trust you,” Vince said, cradling her face as he spoke. “And that I’m ready.”

“You sure about that?”

“No,” Vince admitted. “But I don’t think I’ll get to be totally sure. There’s some inherent risk in connecting with someone deeply. So I’m not sure that it will all end well and I won’t get hurt. I am sure that I consider being with you worth the risk, though.”

Sasha stretched herself upwards and kissed him gently on the bottom lip.

“I’ll be gentle,” she said with a slight smirk.

“Liar,” he replied, kissing her lightly on the nose.

“Perceptive boy,” she said. She leapt atop him once more. This time Vince made no effort at all to stay standing.

## 127.

Roy's punch caught Stella in the sternum, lifting her off the ground and sending her hurtling back several feet. So far they'd just been dancing, a few light taps here and there. This hit, though, this signaled the beginning of the real match.

Stella rolled with the blow as she landed, doing a few spins across the hard dirt floor of the forest and flipping up onto her feet. Roy idly noted that if she'd weighed the same amount as a normal person his punch would have easily sent her all the way to the tree line. They were in a clearing about forty feet across, so that wasn't saying a whole lot, but Roy felt he would have at least appreciated the satisfaction of such a sight.

"That all you got?" Stella taunted as she got her footing. Roy's punch had taken some of the breath from her, a fact she was trying to hide by stalling. She'd been caught off guard; last time she'd seen him fight was at the beginning of the year. Back then he swung wide and blocked minimally. Things had clearly changed in the last few months.

"Not even close," Roy replied with a smile. She was buying time to recover, he was well aware. Hell, he'd gotten more experience at that than any other aspect of fighting in the time he'd been sparring Chad. Roy had no qualms with letting her catch her breath. He wasn't going to let her win, but that didn't mean he felt the need to utterly crush her.

Stella steadied herself and regained control of her breathing. She also took the opportunity to fix the top of her suit slightly. Admittedly, challenging someone to a fight while wearing only a bikini might not have been the smartest move, however Stella Hawkins had never been one for a tremendous amount of forethought.

"Thank god, I was scared I'd get bored," Stella shot back, moving toward him carefully. Roy began advancing as well, a series of small, careful steps with his eyes never swerving from her body.

In a flash of sunset glinting off steel, Stella dashed forward, faking a right before throwing her momentum in a slide. It carried her through Roy's initial punching range before he could adjust to the shift. Taking advantage of the low position and the opportunity, Stella swept her legs around, striking the backs of Roy's knees. They immediately buckled and sent him tumbling forward. Stella readied herself to nail Roy in the torso when he moved to catch himself. Instead she was caught off guard as Roy threw his right leg in



front of him, stopping the descent in a move that would have easily broken the ankle of a normal combatant. Roy pushed off on his heel, reeling against the fall and spinning his body around in time to take a swing at Stella. The punch was too short, but it forced her on the defensive as she scrambled back to her feet. Seconds later they were circling each other once more.

“I make it a personal goal never to bore a lady,” Roy said, flashing Stella his patented smile.

“No, just to infer that we’re weaker, softer, and don’t belong on the battlefield,” Stella replied.

“Am I still inferring? I thought after a certain point it was considered speaking what you were thinking,” Roy said.

“That is fucking it,” Stella said, charging forward. This time she didn’t even bother with a fake blow, she just reared back and swung with a hard right. She was positive he’d be able to block it, she just wanted to make sure it would hurt. Roy caught her by surprise once more though. Rather than try and stop her blow he lowered his head and met it dead on. With his skull.

Stella winced at the unexpected pain, a movement that cost her the chance at seeing Roy’s next move. This was unfortunate, because Roy used his lowered frame and her open right side to catch her dead under the chin with an upward blow. Her eyes flashed with sparks as she was sent sprawling. There was no fancy roll this time, just coughing and clawing at the ground as she tried to regroup. To his credit, Roy made no move to come after her as she recovered, though this only served to agitate her more.

“So what,” Stella said, spitting on the ground and checking to see if she was bleeding. “You don’t press the attack if the opponent is a girl?”

“Could be, or maybe I’m just admiring how nice your ass looks when you’re crouched like that,” Roy responded.

Stella slammed her fist into the ground and pulled herself up. “You are one dead motherfucker.”

“Says the girl who has only landed glancing blows so far.”

“I’m warming up,” Stella lied.

“Sure you are, Sugar Dumpling,” Roy said. He spread his feet apart and readied for another charge. Stella wasn’t the type of opponent one wanted to let catch them off guard.

“Geez, your parents must have really done on a number on you,” she

remarked as she looked for the best angle to attack from.

“That a fact?”

“Yeah, I mean, for you to hate girls as much as you do there must be some really messed up shit in your past,” Stella sniped.

Roy blinked in genuine surprise. “You think I hate girls?”

“Of course you do. You just see us as holes to fuck, not equals,” Stella said, her own rage boiling over and culminating in another charge. There was no good angle to come at, she could see that clearly. No matter what she did he’d be able to counter. His headbutt to her fist had inspired her, though. This wasn’t a fight in the gym, this was a brawl. She didn’t care if he got in some good licks as long as she gave them right back.

Stella slammed her shoulder into Roy’s abs, ignoring the two punches he landed on her shoulder when she came in range. She used her superior weight to drive him back, slamming him against a tree before dragging him to the ground. They crashed into the dirt together, immediately rolling around to get on top. Stella had more experience at groundwork, but the previous blows were muddling her head and Roy’s non-metallic frame gave him an advantage in speed. As a result they soon came to a rest with Roy perched on top of Stella, his knees pinning her chest to the ground.

“For the record,” Roy said, leaning back to avoid her hand that was clawing at his face, “I don’t hate women.”

“Sure, you’re a goddamn patriot of feminism,” Stella huffed from her prone position.

“Probably not,” Roy admitted. “But I don’t hate them.”

Stella stopped struggling for a moment to look up at him. The boy was interrupting a good fight to make this point, it was clearly pretty important in his eyes. And speaking of his eyes, they actually looked sincere at this particular moment. Stella didn’t think she could have ever guessed what sincerity would look like on Roy Daniels, but there it was, plain as day.

“Fine, I’ll concede that you don’t hate women. You don’t think of us as equals, though.”

“Agreed. I think you’re kinder, smarter, and gentler than men can ever hope to be. And yes, physically weaker and softer. Paint me as an asshole all you want, but that’s just how I see it. So I prefer to see woman away from the battlefield, safe where they won’t get hurt. Because the world outside of

combat needs them far more than it needs men, especially men like me,” Roy explained.

“You realize that’s still misogyny, right?” Stella asked.

“Realize it? I don’t even know what it means,” Roy said.

“And all the random sex?”

“I’m an adult, so are they. Everybody likes fucking. I’m not apologizing for that one.” With that he stood up, taking Stella’s hand and jerking her to her feet as well.

Stella accepted his help and brushed herself off. Much as she hated to admit it, her anger had all but completely ebbed away. Yeah, he was six feet and a few hundred pounds of pure dickbrain, but his motivations weren’t quite as pigheaded as she’d thought.

Roy was feeling about the same way. “Guess we’re done with the fight, huh?”

Stella replied by socking him in the ribs. Roy doubled over and began coughing.

“Hell no,” she said. “I might not be mad but I’m still all worked up. Besides, I haven’t had a fight this good in a long time. So there is no way I’m letting you go already.”

“Fine by me,” Roy said, coming back up and rubbing his side tenderly. “I’m good to go all night long.”

“Boys and their empty promises,” Stella said, taking another swing at him as he stepped backward.

The remainder of the fight lasted about five minutes. The sex that followed lasted considerably longer.

## 128.

“So day one was, as you’ve described it here, a ‘hookup bonanza’, correct?”

“Yes, sir,” Angela replied.

“I can certainly see how that would happen,” Dean Blaine said. He turned the page in the packet of documents he was holding. “Now, the forest fire on the second day, that one will require a bit more explanation.”

Ben squirmed around in his chair. The dean’s office was plush and comfortable, but having to answer for the actions of a class of drunken Supers was worse than sitting on pins made of lava.

“It’s really quite simple, sir. You see, some of the students decided to make a campfire at the end of the day. Unfortunately, we were still collecting the tubes and we had the matches, so one of the students chose to do the job himself.”

Dean Blaine cocked an eyebrow. “Would that have been Mr. Reynolds?”

“No, sir, he actually helped us quell it before it got out of hand. The one who started the fire was Allen Wells,” Ben said.

“Ah yes, the young man who can throw explosive balls of energy.”

“Yeah, the idiot figured it would be combusive enough to ignite the nearby wood,” Angela scoffed. “And he was right.”

“Indeed he was. The park service is none too happy with me about the damage left behind,” Dean Blaine said.

“In our defense, we did manage to get it contained very quickly,” Ben pointed out.

“You did, I’ll give you that,” Dean Blaine said. “Though you were somewhat slower in response to the glacier that now occupies a chunk of the river.”

Ben swallowed hard. This was not the way he wanted to spend the first afternoon back from vacation.

\* \* \*

Nick sat on the couch, watching television and applying lotion to the

side of his nose. He'd miscalculated the necessary SPF to defend him all weekend and was now paying the price. The boy knew a lot about sunshine and desert heat, but less about the sunscreen-washing-off properties of a river. Alice walked over from the girls' side, clad in tank top, flip flops, and shorts.

"Sun got you, too?" Nick asked perfunctorily

"Like I owed him money," Alice said. She sat down next to him and pulled out her own bottle of lotion, one that was both more expensive and more effective. "Where is everyone? We've had all morning to rest up, I figured they'd have swung back to life by now."

"They have," Nick said. "Vince left with Sasha a few hours ago. Mary came in a little after lunch, so she and Hershel took off to catch up and be all couple-like."

"Well, they are sort of a couple," Alice noted.

"Thus the word choice."

"Ah," Alice said. "Not to be forward, would you mind getting the backs of my shoulders?"

Nick hesitated for a moment, then said, "Okay." Alice realigned her couch position so her back was facing Nick, then handed him her lotion. She slid the straps of her tank top down to the sides of her arms and pulled her long blonde hair around front, revealing the bare upper half of her back.

"So, when are you going to see Bubbles next?" Alice asked as Nick's hands worked the soothing cream into her skin.

"Probably in a couple of days," Nick said blandly. "I've got stuff to do and what not."

"We didn't have any homework over the break. What kind of stuff do you have?"

"You know, just stuff," Nick reiterated lamely. He was having trouble conjuring up his usual silver tongue, mostly because he was focusing on keeping his physical tells under control. Ever since that kiss in the woods he'd lost his ability to deny that he was physically attracted to Alice. He'd coped with this new development by keeping his distance, but now he was kneading her flesh with his hands and things were getting more difficult. If Nicholas Campbell had any weakness, it was women.

"Just stuff, okay," Alice said, letting it go. "You know, Nick, about the first night of the river trip, there was something I wanted to say."

A lesser man would have let his hand stiffen in fearful anticipation of what was coming next. Nick may not have been a better man; however, he was a better liar. His fingers never paused and his voice betrayed nothing.

“And what’s that?”

“Just that I wanted to say thanks for coming after me. I don’t remember if I ever expressed gratitude; I was pretty drunk, after all. So I just wanted to make sure I thanked you,” Alice said.

Nick relaxed a bit internally and got back to the task at hand. So she didn’t remember things too clearly. That would make proceeding from here much easier.

Had Nick been sitting a few inches to the left he would have been able to see Alice’s face in a mirror that hung on the wall. And had he been gifted with that vantage point, he surely would have noticed the wry, cunning smile on her face.

\* \* \*

Jill was sitting in the central area of their dorm room, reading a magazine. She flipped casually to the next page, ears working hard to ignore the sounds seeping through the walls around her. She zeroed in her attention on an article about toning one’s thighs. For a second she thought she had obtained a Zen level of focus, because the sounds ceased. This theory was disproven moments later when Sasha emerged from her and Julia’s room clad in a pink robe.

“Hey,” Sasha said, making a beeline for the fridge.

“Hey,” Jill said back, turning to another page.

Sasha reached in the fridge and grabbed two bottles of water, then stood at the door for a moment staring into its depths. She reached back in and grabbed four more, juggling the six vessels as she made her way back into her room and firmly shut the door.

Jill sighed. She would get maybe ten or fifteen minutes before the noise would start again. Maybe she would go to the library and read for a while. Or just go for a walk around campus. Or go see what Will was up to.

Jill was still contemplating her options when the ruckus began once more. She needed to have a talk with Sasha about turning on the radio or something during boyfriend time. Really, though, Jill realized she needed to start freaking meeting men. This was just getting insufferable.

\* \* \*

“So all things totaled, you had approximately five thousand dollars’ worth of damage caused by the students under your watch, destroyed a small patch of a national forest, and caused ecological damages to no less than nine different species’ habitats,” Dean Blaine surmised.

“Yes, sir,” Ben said weakly.

“Looks like it,” Angela agreed.

“Well then, good job, you two,” Dean Blaine said, setting down the packet of papers.

“Beg your pardon?” Ben asked.

“That’s one of the least destructive river trips in the last decade. You did your jobs very well. You have my thanks and the thanks of your school.”

“Sweet,” Angela said, hopping up. “So, we done here?”

“Yes, Ms. DeSoto, you are free to go,” Dean Blaine replied.

“Cool; come on, Ben, let’s go grab a late lunch,” she said, tugging on her fellow chaperone’s arm.

“Okay, I guess,” Ben said unsurely, getting out of the chair and allowing himself to be pulled from the room.

Once the door was shut, Dean Blaine turned his attention back to the paperwork required for the cleanup. Even with such minimal damage there were still a lot of forms to file and sign. He briefly wondered how many documents had to be filled out by the dean after his class went on the river trip.

He couldn’t be certain without the hard numbers, but he suspected it was enough that he would quit by way of setting the building on fire should such a pile ever be presented to him.

## 129.

“You all look nice and rested,” Coach George said as he walked in front of the line of members of the combat class. “That’s good. I’m glad you all got time to heal up and re-energize, because we have now entered the last mile of your freshman year. And does everyone remember what happens at the end of your freshman year?”

There was no response; he’d long ago drilled out the habit of speaking without being called on. There was fear, though, fear and uncertainty dancing behind nearly all of their eyes. He’d have preferred to see it in every last set of orbs, but some of them were just too stupid to face the possibility that they wouldn’t make the cut. There were also a few too smart not to know they were a shoe-in.

“That’s right: at the end of the year we have ourselves another set of matches. These won’t just be fighting this time; they’ll test every aspect a Hero needs to bring to the table. Strength, intelligence, cunning, resourcefulness, and yes, even a bit of battle prowess. So keep those memories of your time off tucked away in a nice safe spot in your mind. You’ll need them to keep you sane every night when you crawl into bed, your bones creaking and your spirit crumbling. These next two months will be hell on you because I am going to be personally applying the pitchfork. You see, this is my last chance to get you pansies strong enough to actually survive the second year’s training, and I take that responsibility very seriously. So, do we have any questions?”

Not one person’s hand even dared to entertain a thought about ascending.

“Glad to hear it,” Coach George declared. “Pair up as I call your names and get into your fighting circles. Oh, and we’re changing something up today.”

The students looked at him with an uneven mix of anticipation and trepidation.

Coach George gave them a winning smile. “Today, my little charges, I declare that you have had your asses whipped in mortal ways long enough. As of now, you may begin using your powers.”

There was a physical mumbling, if not a verbal one. It was the sound of backs cinching up in fear, knuckles cracking in excitement, and eyeballs roving in their sockets as they sized up their opponents in a whole new way. If



Coach George could he would record that sound, put in on a loop, and play it continuously as he nodded off to sleep every night.

Instead he began hollering out the pairs.

\* \* \*

“As you all know by now, not every member of this class will make the cut into the sophomore program,” Coach Persephone said, walking in a nearly identical fashion to her male counterpart. “Now, while George likes to take this time to deaden the nerves of his students, I prefer to sharpen the minds of my own.”

Curiosity danced in the eyes of the Supers lined up before her. That was good. Curiosity meant listening and listening meant thinking. Thinking was what would make the difference between success and failure for her charges. That, along with creativity and determination.

“Some of the tests you’ll endure will be combat-based. I won’t sugarcoat it for you: with precious few exceptions, most of you will come out the loser in these encounters.”

The gazes of several faces turned toward the floor.

“That is an acceptable loss, though, because it does not comprise the entirety of these evaluations. Think of it as giving away a pawn in order to take their king. They will hone their bodies and battle instincts over the coming months. We will be honing our minds and adaptability instead. We will double down on our strategic lessons. Your minds will ache with effort and you will tear out your hair in frustration, but you will improve. And at the end of May, when you go into your trials, you will emerge as victorious sophomores.”

It wasn’t the best inspirational speech in the history of the school, but it did seem to bestow her kids with a bit of hope. At this point that was really the best Coach Persephone could shoot for. These Supers were fighting an uphill battle, proving that they were useful even without the ability to fend off an army. When they crested that hill they would understand just how powerful they really were. Until that point, all she could do was keep them working hard in hopes of achieving what most of them saw as impossible.

Persephone at least had the advantage of knowing something they didn’t. Sometimes attaining the impossible was simply a matter of continuously putting one foot in front of the other, no matter what.

\* \* \*

Dean Blaine and four other figures stood in a small room lined with television screens. Normally these screens would show a variety of rooms with different teams from different classes on each one. Today, however, they showed different angles of the two rooms where the freshman class was being addressed.

“Interesting crop,” said the smallest figure, a woman’s whose voice had seen its share of days.

“That’s what you say every year,” Dean Blaine pointed out.

“It’s true every year,” she countered.

Dean Blaine had no rebuttal to this - he never did - so instead he moved on to the task at hand.

“You’ve seen their files, you’ve watched the tapes, and you know their names. Today we divvy them up, and you have one and a half months to devise their test, then half a month to get it all set up,” Dean Blaine explained.

“George and Persephone already made their picks?” This time the voice came from a tall, male figure.

“Turned them in to me before Spring Break,” Dean Blaine said.

“Such a prompt pair,” said a new female voice, this one young and lilting.

“Would that I could see such efficiency from the rest of you,” Dean Blaine said.

“Let’s be fair, you don’t keep us around because we adhere so well to the red tape,” said the old voice.

“No, but I still expect you to take tasks like this seriously. You have the room for the next two hours. Make your selections and have them on my desk by the end of the day,” Dean Blaine instructed them. He walked briskly out the door before any other snide comments could be made.

“Now then,” said the fourth figure, a voice like silk being torn thread by thread, “I think it’s time to get down to business.”

## 130.

“Shit!” Coach George yelled, diving for cover. The errant bolt of electricity sizzled by his head, narrowly missing him. Instead it stuck a hard concrete outcropping a few feet behind him as other bolts followed different paths to similar results.

“Sorry,” Vince said sheepishly. The first time he’d been tripping over himself in concern that he’d wounded his teacher, but truthfully, after so many near misses the initial panic had become notably subdued.

“No harm done, Coach George assured him. “Refuel and try again.”

Vince and Coach George were having a one-on-one session for ranged training. They were in a room with exceptional insulation and no electrical conduits or metal. Coach George hadn’t been exaggerating about the variety of resources at Lander. They really did have a room for nearly every conceivable training necessity. That was proving to be a very good thing, because by George’s calculations the kid would have caused hundreds of thousands of dollars in wiring damage by now if they’d been outside this room.

“Yes, sir,” Vince said, jogging back over to the car battery at the edge of the room. In the weeks they’d been training he hadn’t been having much luck, so they were now trying a new tactic. Instead of draining the battery at once, Vince only took a little bit of electricity at a time, used it in an attack, then drained a little more. This had two benefits in that it allowed a single battery to fuel him for a long training session, and it kept the damage from being too spectacular when his blasts went off course, which, to date, was pretty much every time he threw one.

“Let’s decrease the distance again,” Coach George suggested once Vince had, in a sense, reloaded.

Vince nodded and approached a small pile of concrete on the ground. So far they’d tried breathing techniques, aiming techniques, and even rubber gloves with the fingers cut out. None of it had kept the electricity from splintering, so now they had gone back to basics. The only time Vince had successfully used electricity was against Thomas with a very small gap between them. The new set of tests was to see if there was a distance which was small enough that it didn’t allow time for the energy to slip out of control. If such a measurement did exist, then the next step would be to increase it.

“How far this time?” Vince asked.

“Last time we did forty feet. This time let’s take it to thirty,” Coach George told him. He repositioned himself carefully behind his student. While a shot of lightning certainly wasn’t going to kill someone like George, that didn’t mean it was something he was chomping at the bit to experience. Especially not in his human form.

Vince narrowed his focus and slowed his breathing. He concentrated on the pile of rocks in front of him, on the spot just at the very top. He raised his hand carefully, his fingers tentatively outstretched. Vince imagined the electricity, bright blue and white hot, arcing from his palm to the rocks in a single, brilliant beam. He held that vision firmly in his mind, drowning out the rest of the world. Nothing existed outside the room. There was no coach standing behind him. Even he didn’t exist, nothing permeated this world save the rocks, his hand, and the arc that would connect them. Vince expelled a breath outward and let the energy fly.

It struck seven different spots, though to give appropriate credit one of them was fairly close to the rock clump.

“Crap,” Vince swore.

“Chin up, Reynolds,” Coach George said, walking forward. “Believe it or not, this is progress. It didn’t split up as much this time.”

“Yeah,” Vince agreed, dejection slithering in his voice. “So that means if I get really close it probably won’t splinter at all.”

“And that’s a good thing,” Coach George reminded him.

“It is and it isn’t. To be honest, I was holding out hope that the reason I was able to use electricity against Thomas was something to do with my mindset, or my technique. That way I could learn it, master it, and begin relying on a new form of energy in combat.”

“Which is what we’re doing.”

“Not exactly. What we’re really doing is finding at what distance the lightning separates. That isn’t me affecting anything except how close I can be when I use it. I suppose I would just prefer overcoming a personal limitation to a physical one.”

“Heh, that in itself makes you an oddball,” Coach George said. “Listen, Reynolds, this kind of thing is a process with any power. First you get the concept of it, then you find its flaws and limits, then you figure out how to circumvent as many as you can. It’s something all Heroes have to go through, and it can take a long-ass time. Hell, why do you think we put you

through four years of this before you're even allowed to work under an existing Hero in the field?"

"I just wish I had better control," Vince said.

Coach George patted him on the back. "That's the hardest part of all this. Throwing cars, bouncing off bullets, jumping between continents, all that shit is easy if you've got the gift. But knowing how to do it safely, and, even more importantly, when to do it, those are the real skills a Hero needs to master."

"I guess that means I won't be adding lightning to my arsenal anytime soon," Vince noted.

"Maybe, maybe not," Coach George said. "The best arsenals are versatile ones. So if we find out you can't use electricity safely from more than ten feet then yeah, you won't be including it in your ranged repertoire. On the other hand, it could be a devastating technique to whip out in close combat. Even if it was down to a few inches, you could make it so that every punch you throw is an over-clocked taser."

Vince considered the idea and thought back to his first fight of the year with Michael. If his one punch had carried just a little extra juice, the whole thing could have turned out differently.

"That might not be a bad idea," Vince admitted.

"Glad to hear an eighteen-year-old believes I can actually do my job," Coach George said. "Go refuel."

"Yes, sir," Vince repeated, jogging back to the battery. If nothing else, this training was giving a lot of experience in controlling how much energy he took from a source rather than draining it dry. That was one skill he was exceptionally happy to master. It was a constant, daily reminder that no matter how much trouble he might be having, at least he wasn't Powered anymore.

That was usually enough to lift his spirits quite effectively.

## 131.

“As our year begins drawing closer to its end, I would like to move our conversations to more summary topics,” Dean Blaine said. He’d been taking it a little easier on them in the past few weeks, well aware that George and Persephone would be turning up the heat and stressing them out. Add that to the demands from their regular classes and it could be argued that the real point of this semester was training in how to handle eye-gouging levels of stress. An argument, by the way, that would not be entirely off point.

“So today, I wanted to talk about the HCP as a whole. We take people with extraordinary abilities and a desire to help, and we refine them into nigh-unstoppable warriors of justice. Yet at the same time, we take others with equally amazing talents and cast them out, telling them they are forbidden from getting involved when they see innocents in distress. The question I pose to you is why? Why do we insist so emphatically that the only person worthy of wearing the title of Hero is someone who has been given this course’s full education?”

“Everyone knows that,” Stella said. “Insurance.”

“If you’re going to speak out of turn you could at least present a fully-formed argument,” Dean Blaine chastised her.

“Okay,” Stella said. “I mean, it’s really obvious. People with abilities can cause a whole lot of collateral damage, even more so when they are fighting someone else with powers. That means people filing insurance claims for their homes and businesses. The companies really hate paying out all that money, though. They’d make us quit getting in fights, but regular law enforcement agencies aren’t able to able people with strong powers. At least, not as effectively as we can. So since they can’t tell us not to stop Supers who are killing and stealing, and they can’t refuse to pay out every time one of us causes damage, the only other option is to demand that the people stopping them, the people we call Heroes, have been properly trained to minimize that collateral damage. That’s why the training and certification started; it was so Supers could do their job without being held financially liable for every flipped truck and melted mailbox that wound up in their wake.”

Dean Blaine blinked in surprise, as did a large amount of the class. Stella, while forceful, was rarely so well-informed on a topic.

“That was an excellent, well-reasoned theory,” Dean Blaine said.

“My dad is an insurance adjuster,” Stella said by way of explanation.

“I see, that sheds a little light on it,” Dean Blaine said. “And Ms. Hawkins is correct. The roots of the HCP are most certainly in the goal of allowing those with special talents to use them to help people without being afraid of fiscal reprisal. That was the beginning, though, designed to suit a program far less expansive than our current HCP. So who else can tell me why we hold our defenders to such rigorous standards?”

This time several hands went up. Dean Blaine called on the fastest to get it out of the way.

“Yes, Ms. Adair?”

“Because we have to know more than just how to do the least damage to a city block. We need to know how to avoid, or least limit, civilian casualties. We need to know how to deal with hostage situations, and how to cope with the political implications of chasing someone across international lines. Being a Hero means people are trusting you with their lives. We need to be as best prepared to live up to that trust as possible,” Alice said.

“Very good,” Dean Blaine said. “However, as with the insurance, these are things that are already widely known and accepted as reasons for the HCP. I’m more looking for things that you, as participants, can appreciate that an outsider wouldn’t understand the necessity of.”

Most of the hands went down at this stipulation. A few stayed raised, though, and Dean Blaine perused his pickings, selecting one after a few seconds of analysis.

“Mr. DeSoto.”

“We’re learning humility,” Shane said. “Most of us came from towns where, if we weren’t the only Super, we were one of very few. We grew up feeling like we were untouchable. We aren’t, and some people needed to experience that firsthand to believe it.”

“Now, that is an excellent one,” Dean Blaine complimented. “Few people not in the program would understand just how important losing is. Mr. Wells, what is another example?”

“We’re learning what to really expect,” Allen said. “Before this class it had never occurred to me how many hard choices would come with being a Hero. I thought of it as just blasting away at bad guys. Knowing what I do now, I’m approaching this potential future with a lot more caution. I still want to do it, but I have a better idea of what I’m in for. If I’d had to face some of the tough situations in the field, with no mental preparation, it could have ranged from problematic to traumatic, depending on how bad things got.”

“Quite true,” Dean Blaine agreed. “The preparation of the mind is, in my opinion, one of the most undervalued necessities we instill here at Lander. Mr. Campbell, do you have another point you’d like to add?”

Nick’s hand hadn’t been up, but he rolled with the question anyway. Dean Blaine had made it clear long ago that the hand system was ancillary: he would call on whoever he pleased to answer him.

“The physical training,” Nick replied. “I mean, yeah, most people get that a Hero needs to be strong, but how many understand that he needs to have stamina, flexibility, and pain endurance even when he isn’t a front-line fighter? I think outsiders picture us just lifting buses and chewing on nails. They don’t appreciate the full range of effort we have to put in just to be adequate in a support capacity, let alone a front-line one.”

“A bit obvious, but valid, I’ll give you,” Dean Blaine said. “Now, that’s all focusing on the positive, what you get out of being here. That isn’t the entirety of the process, however. For every student who graduates there are tens to hundreds that tried for that spot. Putting aside obvious concerns about physical capability, why do we keep them out? Wouldn’t it make more sense to allow everyone help who wants to do so?”

“No,” Vince said, speaking up. “Because not everyone should be a Hero.”

“Would you like to elaborate, Vince?”

“I just mean that being looked up to, and exalted, that comes with a lot of prestige. A lot of power. That’s going to attract plenty of Supers, not just ones who genuinely want to help. It’s not a bad idea to have some sort of filter before we just hand out a title that tells everyone this is a person they can trust and rely on,” Vince explained.

“You’re quite right,” Dean Blaine said. “Heroes are trusted by civilians and governments alike. We have to be very careful who we give such responsibility to, and not just in case they have less-than-pure intentions. Who can tell me another danger of letting anyone through the HCP?”

“Because the worst-case scenario is that someone starts as a genuine Hero and then turns,” said Chad, face staring down at his desk.

“Go on,” Dean Blaine said softly.

“A Super who commits crimes is a pain for the regular people to deal with, but Heroes can handle most of them in relatively short order. When a Hero turns, on the other hand, he doesn’t just bring his abilities to the table.



He brings all the training he received in the HCP, all the combat experience he acquired on the job, all the secrets he was made privy to, and all the trust that other Heroes have in him. When a Hero turns away from the law, entire towns get destroyed and other Heroes almost always die.”

“There is a very unfortunate amount of truth in that statement,” Dean Blaine said. “It is one of the key reasons we screen so thoroughly before admitting someone to the HCP. We seek to determine not only who they are, but also who they will become over time. It is a difficult task, and one we put tremendous effort and resources into. However, we are not, I’m sad to say, always successful.”

## 132.

The class looked like life had come after them in a dark alley wielding a sock full of quarters. They were haggard, tired, and worn. Since the return from break, George and Persephone had kept their promise, treating each gym session as though it were their final chance to enact some sort of long-festering revenge on the students in their charge.

The battles were brutal, the mental exercises exhausting, and there was constant drilling of strategies historically used by different Heroes. The end result was that as the class gathered on Friday afternoon, they didn't fall into line so much as gradually limp there. Some of them were suffering from literal physical pains: the class had just ended and they hadn't had a chance to meet with the healer yet. Others were simply laboring under a weary spirit, demonstrating physical distress as outlet for what they were coping with internally.

"You all look like utter shit," Coach George said as they finished lining up. "And with only three weeks left until finals. I don't think most of you could take on a sack full of terminal kittens right now, let alone a trained warrior wielding superhuman abilities."

The class stood stoically, most of them in healthy agreement of his assessment.

"A mind is like a knife," Coach Persephone said, taking her turn to walk down the line. "It must be kept sharp, bright, and always at the ready. Look at you all. Half of you haven't even been able to hear this whole speech, that's how much your brains are glossing over."

Again the coaches were met with a weathered, beaten silence.

"It is for these reasons that things will be changing a bit," Coach George said. "Persephone and I feel that we have taken you as far as you are capable of going in the time allotted to us. That isn't to say we couldn't whip your squishy asses into beasts if we had a decade to play with, but all we were given was a single school year. So, rather than drive you into the ground one by one over the remaining time before your exam, we're taking a different approach."

"As of Monday," Coach Persephone announced, "you are all ordered to be on rest for one week."

There was a ripple through the students, certain their feeble minds had

snapped and full-blown delusion had set in.

“The gym, the training rooms, and all the facilities will be completely off limits to you during those seven days,” Coach Persephone continued. “Once that time had passed, you will spend the remaining two weeks undergoing a personalized training regimen. By that we mean you will work out in the ways that you find most effective. This can occur during your formerly scheduled gym time, or whenever you have free time. We are legally obligated to remind you that staying in the HCP requires the maintaining of a C average or better, so budget your time between training and study wisely.”

Looks were now being exchanged, each seeking clarification from the others that this was really happening.

“During these two weeks, Coach Persephone and I will be on hand, should any of you wish to schedule time with us for personal tutorials. That will be the limit of our involvement from now until your exam, though,” Coach George said.

“And one last piece of business,” Coach Persephone said. “Many of you have noticed that there is a day between the last finals at Lander University and the commencement of your test here in the HCP. This day is used as a dead day for final preparations and recovery. It is something of a tradition, however, for the staff to put on a small festival for the students on the night testing is over. It will occur in the gym, and there will be food, some dancing, and games. This is done as a stress-relieving outlet, and to buffer between the sets of finals. We hope to see you all here.”

With that, she and Coach George turned and made a swift exit. They never turned back once, yet the students still didn’t begin to mill about until several moments after the doors had swung shut.

\* \* \*

“Can anyone else not believe that just freaking happened?” Nick said as the group walked briskly toward Melbrook.

“It makes a lot of sense, if you really think about it,” Mary pointed out. “We’re supposed to be at our peak for the exam. That’s hard to pull off when we’re getting pummeled every week.”

“No kidding,” Roy agreed. “Even I’m starting to feel it after these past few months. Three more weeks and I think Chad would be the only man able to still stay standing on test day.”

“Roy Daniels, did you just admit you think someone is stronger than

you?” Mary gasped.

“Only for now,” Roy replied with a smarmy grin.

“Yeah, well, this is a boon none of us expected, and I say we celebrate,” Nick tossed out. “I’ll go to the video store-”

The group groaned collectively.

“Not another bad movie night,” Alice protested. “Literally, anything but that.”

“Literally? Okay then, how about a rousing game of strip twister?” Nick asked.

“One day some lucky girl is going to castrate you, and I sincerely hope I’m around to see it,” Alice replied.

“All dong mangling aside, I’m with the chicks on this one,” Roy agreed. “Even Hershel is tired of those things.”

“You guys are nuts, my choice in horrific cinema is the stuff of legend. Back me up here, Vince,” Nice said.

“Yeah, whatever you guys want,” Vince said, his eyes shifting about. “I’ve got something to take care of real quick. I’ll see you back at the dorm.”

With that, Vince was jogging off hastily, backpack bouncing against him as he dashed.

“That was odd,” Nick observed.

“Let him be,” Mary said. “He’ll be back soon.”

Nick glanced at her momentarily, then shrugged it off.

“Whatever, I say we start with the *Death Couch II* and *Death Couch IV* just to set the mood-”

This time the group groan was louder and held for a full thirty seconds.

## 133.

There was a timid knock on George's door.

"Come in, Reynolds," Coach George called out, not even glancing up from his work.

Vince stepped in slowly, working his way forward and standing in front of the desk.

"How did you know it was me?"

"Because my superiors and colleagues don't knock, and you're the only frequent student visitor who hits the door like he's scared it will hit back."

"Oh. Sorry, I guess," Vince said.

"Don't worry about it, kid. On my list of stuff to watch out for, someone who knocks softly isn't exactly on top. So, what can I do for you?"

"I wanted to schedule some one-on-one time to work on my electricity techniques."

Coach George let out a sigh. "I was afraid you were going to say that. Take a seat, Reynolds."

Vince complied and plopped down in the available chair.

"We've been at this for months now, and what we've discovered is that at a distance of more than a few inches, your electricity arcs wild every time. When it does it's impossible to determine which direction it's going. Hell, half the time it doesn't even include the initial target in the spray of places it strikes," Coach George pointed out.

"Yes, sir," Vince agreed. "That's why I'm here to schedule time. So I can get better."

"And I applaud that kind of spirit, that a problem is only a problem until you work through it. That said, you've got three weeks until we put you through one of the hardest tests of your life. You're going to need to be in peak form. So do you think there might be a better way to spend your time?"

"I'm confused; are you telling me to give up on using electricity?"

"Absolutely not," Coach George said emphatically. "I've known Supers who would kill for the level of versatility your power gives you. What

I'm saying is that sometimes it's all about time management. You have two weeks of allowed training time. Now, what do you think will pay off more for your test: struggling to invent a way to utilize electricity, or polishing up and refining what you can do with fire?"

"I guess that would depend on if I succeeded with the electricity or not," Vince said honestly.

"Not really," Coach George disagreed. "It's two weeks, not two months. Even if you do neglect other parts of your training and manage to find a way to control the bolts, you're not going to have time to master it. The best-case scenario is you walk out there with an unrefined technique that may or may not play out well, as opposed to being fresh and ready with an element you know how to use."

"I suppose there's logic in that," Vince admitted. "I still want to learn better electrical control, though."

"I'm one hundred percent behind you on that, kid. All I'm saying is pick your timing. Playing with new stuff is for down time. This is crunch time. Crunch time is for focusing on what you've got."

"Yes, sir, I think I'll do that," Vince agreed. He stood from the chair. "Thank you for your time, and for the advice."

"That's why they pay me the big bucks," Coach George said. "And for what it's worth, kid, I hope to see you back here next year."

"Thank you," Vince said, stepping out of the office. He wasn't certain, but he was pretty sure he'd just experienced the closest thing to a compliment Coach George was capable of imparting.

\* \* \*

A manila envelope fell out of Michael Clark's locker as he pulled the door open. He had just finished doing some extra Friday training before the ban went into effect and was going to grab his clothes to change back. This envelope was a new addition to his items, one he hadn't added. Michael reached down and scooped up the envelope, cursorily noting it seemed to be moderately thick with contents.

He glanced around, almost more out of obligation than expectation. If someone slipped an envelope into his locker like this, it was highly unlikely they were going to stick around to be seen. He'd been training for three hours, so that left an enormous window of time for anyone to come in here and squeeze in it through an opening in the door. No, the only viable clue to the

envelope's origins was the envelope itself.

Michael carefully undid the metal clasp and pulled out the first few pages. Some were newspapers clippings, some were police reports, some were just random photographs. There didn't seem to be any theme throughout them; not one that Michael could discern, anyway.

Michael was about to toss the mystery back into his locker when something in one of the photographs caught his eye. Michael's breath froze in his throat, an electrical burst of wonder jolting through his system. He looked through the documents again, this time with a better sense of what to check for. He scoured them for five solid minutes before he realized he was still standing in the gym locker room. The cold air and blazing excitement swirled in contrast as he sprang into action. Hurriedly he threw his street clothes on, tucked the envelope carefully into his gym bag, and made a bolt for the lifts that would take him to his dorm.

As soon as he arrived, Michael locked the door tight. His eyes danced briefly to a bottle of scotch in the corner. Michael brushed the thought away immediately. He could, and would, drink later to celebrate.

Right now he had work to do.

## 134.

“It’s official,” Hershel said as the credits began to roll. “We never let Nick pick another movie. All in favor?”

A reverberating chorus of “Aye!” momentarily deafened everyone in the room.

“You guys just don’t appreciate good cinematography,” Nick defended.

“By all means, please explain to me the cinematographic brilliance of *Blood Fountain 3: The Bloodening*,” Sasha dared.

“For starters, there was the way the splatter patterns always caught the light in just the right way to maximize the sensation of gore,” Nick said. In response he was struck in the face by a pillow, hurled from across the room by Alice. Nick turned his head and glared in response, only to be met by an innocent smile and a covert point toward Alex. Nick wasn’t buying it, partially because he wasn’t stupid and partially because he had seen her do the tossing in his peripheral vision. Nick snatched the pillow from the ground, reared back, and let fly at his blonde target.

The pillow ceased its trajectory in mid-air, floating slowly into Mary’s lap. She was nestled on the couch with Hershel, and while his arm wasn’t wrapped around her, their proximity was far closer than that of platonic friends.

“No pillow fighting in the living room,” Mary said. “That’s how things get broken.”

Nick stuck out his tongue. “You suck, Mom.”

Vince laughed. “You know, if anyone in this dorm had the authority to play the mother role, it would be Mary.”

“I don’t think that’s true,” Mary began, though her speech faltered when she noticed the entire population of the room, which consisted of the Melbrook residents along with Will, Jill, Alex, and Sasha, all nodding in agreement.

“It’s a good thing,” Alice assured her. “It just means you’re the only one who can put everyone in place. Also, I mean, you are kind of the mom.”

“How am I the mom?”



“You stop us from throwing pillows in the house,” Nick pointed out.

“You make us all get salads at dinner,” Vince added.

“You make sure everyone has done their homework each night,” Alice said.

“You’ve said before if you could have a car it would be a mini-van,” Hershel said delicately.

“Oh, don’t you start,” Mary said, thrusting a finger into Hershel’s chest.

“Sorry,” Hershel said, an very unapologetic smile visible on his face.

“Oh!” Jill said, sitting up excitedly. “I’ve got one. You always seem to have Kleenex or tissue on hand.”

“Okay, okay, I get it!” Mary tossed up her hands in mock frustration. “I’m the mom. You got me. Yeesh, part of me is glad I’ve only got three more weeks of you people.”

“Three weeks to cram with as much vintage cinema as possible,” Nick said. This time he ducked the pillow Alice chunked at him. He was not so lucky, however, with the one thrown by Mary.

“I thought you said no pillow throwing,” Nick coughed as he dislodged the pillow from his chest.

“Who’s your mommy now?” Mary retuned with a Cheshire grin.

Nick reared back to return fire, but Vince leaned forward and deftly plucked the projectile from his hand.

“I’ll be the mom. No throwing pillows indoors. Besides, you know she’ll just catch it halfway there and send it back at you,” Vince said.

“True. You combat types and your ranged deflecting capabilities,” Nick said.

“Part of it is that, part of it is that she’s planning on spending her next three weeks training instead of watching movies. Funny how much that can add to one’s skill level,” Vince pointed out.

“Three weeks? You’ve got to be kidding me. I think at this point if we aren’t good to go we might as well just pack our crap,” Nick replied.

“Have any of you guys thought about that?” Alex asked tentatively.

“Thought about the test? Sure, it’s been a worry for me and an excitement for Roy ever since they announced it,” Hershel said.

“No, I mean have you thought about what happens if you fail the test? About what it would be like to not come back next year,” Alex clarified.

“Oh,” Hershel said as the meaning set in. “A little bit. To be honest, I haven’t worried about it a whole lot. Roy has gotten amazingly better throughout the year, especially since he started sparring with Chad. I don’t think he’s going to be top of the class, but I’m pretty sure we won’t get sent home.”

“I might,” Alice said, her voice lightly tremoring with fear. “I mean, I do well at some of the puzzle and strategy exercises, but I haven’t made any progress in finding new ways to use my power. I just fly. That’s all I’ve ever done, and I’m not sure if that’s going to cut it.”

“Flying is a useful ability,” Vince assured her. “The first rule in every battle is ‘Capture the High Ground’. Elevation is important for a lot of different strategies.”

“Useful? Sure, I’ll agree with that. But we’re not talking about just being useful, we’re talking about becoming a Hero.”

“By that logic, several of us are at high risk,” Will chimed in. “My talents are most often assessed to be utilized in support role rather than a primary one. Your power is somewhat limited in its applications. Alex is little more than a weaker form of Mary, and Nick’s power is nebulous and ill-defined at its best.”

“Wow, way to cheer everyone up,” Jill said, noting the downcast faces throughout the room.

“I wasn’t finished yet,” Will said. “My point was that failure is a constant possibility for us. We can’t alter the abilities we were given, so the only thing within our control is to press forward with all we possess. We must train relentlessly, fight unyieldingly, and refuse to surrender in spite of all odds. These are qualities needed not just to make it through another round of the HCP, but ones we must absolutely have if we truly wish to be Heroes.”

“That was surprisingly eloquent,” Sasha said.

“I have my moments,” Will replied.

“Much as I agree with Will, I feel obligated to point out that we have been banned from training for the next week,” Nick said. “So I think it is our

duty as both students and as potential fail-outs from the HCP to try and enjoy ourselves a bit. You know, just in case.”

“I can’t believe I’m saying this, but I agree with Nick,” Mary admitted.

“It only burns the first time,” Vince told her. He glanced at Sasha, who gave a shrug and kissed him on the cheek. “I guess we’re in for whatever.”

The others nodded in a noncommittal fashion, which Nick chose to interpret as an unflinching, complete adherence to any word he spoke.

“Awesome,” Nick said. “Now, to start us off right, the multiplex downtown is doing a blood and gore marathon tomorrow night-”

It was at this point he was forced to vault behind the chair to escape the spontaneous, coordinated barrage of pillows directed at his body.

## 135.

Alice leaned back in her chair and let out a groan.

“Ugh. I’m sick of this. What asshole created calculus in the first place?”

Mary glanced up from her own pile of books. “I think Isaac Newton is credited with a lot of it.”

Alice arched an eyebrow. “The gravity guy? I can see why the apple took a swing at him.”

“That’s actually just a story,” Mary said, her eyes going back to her work. “Like Einstein failing math as a kid. I think they circulate them to make geniuses seem more human.”

“After spending a week reading over this crap, people who comprehend calculus seem less human to me than the coffee maker,” Alice replied. She stretched her back with a series of audible pops and settled back down to her own tasks.

The duo was sitting in the library, the above-ground one for all Lander students, along with several hundred of their peers. With finals pressing down on them, the Lander populace was hitting the books with the determination available only to the truly committed and the incredibly desperate. Oddly, the two categories were often one and the same. Every table in the place was occupied, with an abundance of students prowling along the walls, eyes darting about for any seat about to become open. The instant it did there was a mad flurry of movement, concluding in triumph for one lucky soul and bitter failure for the others. If any of them paused to reflect on just how much study time they were wasting by trying to study alongside everyone else, the thought had as much effect as pointing out to an amateur writer how much time and money they wasted each day by insisting to commute to Starbucks to pound out their masterpieces in view of apathetic patrons.

Alice and Mary had set up shop earlier in the day, staking out a table and leaving only in shifts while the remaining girl gave death glares to anyone approaching the empty chair. They’d been working together as finals drew closer, keeping the other accountable for the amount of effort they had to put in for each class. It was, of course, tempting to slack off, but with the other always at hand, giving the guilt eyes, they’d managed to stay on track for all their tests so far.

“Shouldn’t we be devoting more time to training?” Alice asked a few minutes later.

“Think it will make a difference?” Mary asked.

“Honestly... no. Not really. I think I’ll just need to warm up for a few days before. I don’t see me getting much better than where I’m at, though,” Alice admitted.

“Same here. Think another few hours figuring out this math will help?”

“Eeeeeerrrrrrmmmmmmmm... probably,” Alice yielded.

“Then back to it,” Mary replied. “Only another two hours and we can break for dinner.”

“That’ll be nice,” Alice said.

“Yeah. Plus we can use flash cards to drill each other while we eat,” Mary pointed out.

The thump of Alice’s head slamming into her books was loud enough to draw a chorus of shushes from the nearby tables.

\* \* \*

Alex turned the page in his book and let out a deep breath. Unlike the girls, he was doing his study time alone in his dorm room. His roommate was off training his body for the exam, so Alex had the place to himself. That was a good thing; he functioned best in peace and quiet.

Alex sat cross-legged on his bed, a biology book resting comfortably in his lap. All around the small room various objects were floating in the air. Pencils, books, toothpaste, and a pillow were just some of the levitated furnishings. About once an hour Alex would add another object to the fray, splitting his concentration into yet another new direction. He’d been at this for a few days, and he’d successfully raised the maximum he could handle while studying from fourteen to nineteen. His goal was to hit twenty-five before the exam.

On that note, Alex realized it had been an hour. He mentally scooped up his alarm clock a few feet from the ground and turned the page in his book. Alex felt really bad for the people who had to pick between working on their academics and their HCP material. For his money there was no strategy quite like multi-tasking.

\* \* \*

To the untrained eye it would look like Nick was watching television in the middle of the afternoon when he should have been studying. To the trained eye it would look the same, except they might notice the depression on the couch and the lines on his face that indicated he had been there all day. Nick let out a yawn and switched the channel.

He'd have to go out with Bubbles tonight - she was proving to be too excellent an excuse and shield to let go of anytime soon - but for now he was just relaxing. He'd browsed through his class materials on the first day off and decided he had an A- to C-grade understanding of everything he would be tested on. That meant he was free to use his study time to sit in front of the television while mind-numbing schlock flickered across the screen. It would have been a terrible strategy to employ... if he'd actually been watching it.

The problem with both the trained and untrained eye is that they wouldn't see the cogs whizzing about in Nick's brain. They wouldn't know that he was going back through his entire year, day by day, interaction by interaction, and scanning each minute for information about the people he'd be coming up against. No set of eyes, regardless of training, could discern that the boy lounging lazily was in fact readying himself for his upcoming trials by searching out every weak point and emotional lever he could find in his opponents.

Which, of course, was exactly the reason Nick's body told the story of a boy blowing off his academic responsibilities.

\* \* \*

Thomas fought the urge to vomit while struggling to gulp down some air. His entire body was slick with sweat as he pressed his hand against the cold concrete of the training cell for support. He'd been down here for hours, and he would be here for hours more.

Thomas had used his week off of training to think long and hard about new ways to apply his power in combat. He'd been unable to think of anything entirely new, but he had recalled a technique he'd tried and failed at when he was younger. Deciding to give it the old college try, Thomas had spent his first several days back in the gym making it work. He'd eventually succeeded, leaving him less than a week and a half to get this new strategy to a point where it was viable in combat.

Coach George would have undoubtedly encouraged him to use his time more wisely, and Thomas would in no way have listened. He'd been

beaten in the first trials of the year by being ill-prepared for what his fellow students would bring to bear. Now things were different. Now they'd had months upon months to see the capabilities of each person's power. Now there were no surprises left.

No surprises, except for what one could conjure in the scant two weeks afforded to them. Thomas finished catching his breath and stood up straight. A vibrant orange glow emanated from his hands. His days were short.

It was time to train.

## 136.

Roy caught the fist aimed at his head and twisted it to the right. Stella let out a muffled groan of pain as her shoulder was jerked and her body sent sprawling. Roy turned to intercept the next attacker and received a kick in the ribs from a highly-dense foot. The only sound he could manage was a muffled cough as he doubled over, trying to catching his breath.

“Gotta be quicker than that,” Violet scolded as she stepped back so he could recover.

“And here... I thought... chicks... dug... lasting power,” Roy wheezed out as his lungs did their best to recuperate.

“Real women need speed and longevity,” Violet said, flashing him a smarmy grin of her own. “Speaking of, how you holding up, Stella?”

“Arm is sore,” Stella growled. “No worries, though, I’ll get him back.”

“Good,” Violet said. “Because in twenty minutes it’s your turn.”

“Fuck to the yes,” Stella said, stretching her limbs as she finished standing up.

The three of them had been going for a few days like this, doing one-on-one fights at first, then progressing to two against one. They were each doing some exercises in their own time as well. At the end of the day, however, they all subscribed to the same mentality: the only way to prep for a fight is to fight. A lot.

“That’s enough girl talk,” Roy said, rearing up to his full height. “I’ve still got twenty minutes left, and I want to see just how well you two can double team a man.”

“I swear, it’s like he wants us to aim for the balls,” Violet sighed, taking a stance and bracing herself.

“Well, let’s be honest,” Roy said. “With ones as big as mine, it’d harder not to hit them.”

Stella and Violet exchanged glances. After several days of Roy’s banter, they were getting used to his thinly-veiled attempts to rile them up so they’d come at him harder. That said, they were also very much beginning to enjoy when it was his turn to get attacked.



\* \* \*

Camille exhaled and shifted her position. The sun was just cresting over the horizon as she sat on the hill, knees situated on a soft yet durable blue mat. She was doing yoga, as she did most mornings, though this time she was doing it outside. She was near the edge of the campus, away from where most people traveled, but still within range of being discovered. That was the real point of today: to risk people seeing her.

She wasn't indecent; she wore a baggy shirt over a sports bra and some cloth pants. She was just making strange motions with her body and that was a little embarrassing. Camille didn't particularly like to be watched; she didn't like to stand out in the crowd. It was undoubtedly a survival mechanism left over from her years of abuse at the hands of neighborhood bullies who hated her for being different.

Camille inhaled and rotated her legs. None of that mattered anymore. She wasn't the weirdo of her school, she wasn't the outcast cowering behind the bushes, willing her pursuers to not find her. She wasn't helpless. Camille was a Super. She'd owned that term for years now, and if she wanted to take it to the next level, that meant keeping her concentration in the face of distractions.

A set of voices reached her ears from some distance away. They were getting closer; soon they'd come upon her doing her morning exercise. Her breath tried to catch in her throat, but Camille refused to let it. It was fine if people saw her. It was okay to be noticed. There was nothing wrong with being seen. She had to come to terms with that, because if it came to a point where she had to use her full potential in this test, people were going to notice the living crap out of her. And she had to push through that. She had to be strong. No matter what, she had to advance to the next year.

She knew that He would advance. He would undoubtedly be here next year, fighting and training and laughing and growing. He would be one step closer toward being a Hero. And He would need someone to heal him.

Camille exhaled as she lowered her hips and raised her shoulders. She heard the people walking by her, felt their eyes as they noticed the small, pale-haired girl stretching in the sunrise. She felt the blood rise in her cheeks, but otherwise showed no response. Soon the voices passed and Camille changed position again.

He would be here next year, and He would unavoidably get himself into trouble. He would get hurt. So Camille and her power would be here, too. That's all there was to it.

## 137.

Shane knocked on Michael's door again. He and Chad waited patiently for a few moments before Shane turned around.

"Still no answer."

"I'm aware," Chad said.

"That's weird, though, right? Michael has his crap, but the guy never flakes on training."

Chad shrugged with the casual apathy Shane had grown accustomed to. "Pressure makes some people better, it makes some people break. Maybe he couldn't take it."

"I guess. That just doesn't seem like him," Shane said.

"Yes, because Michael has shown such excellent coping mechanisms throughout the year," Chad replied.

"Never this bad, though," Shane pointed out.

"That's why it is called escalation," Chad told him. "Look, he isn't picking up his cell and I can hear through the walls that he isn't in there. Let's give him the benefit of the doubt and assume he's off doing some special training on his own. In the meantime, you and I have only a few days left."

Shane started to protest, then thought better of it. Michael had barely shown up for three days of training throughout the two weeks, and he'd been distracted each time. Shane considered Michael a friend, but whatever was going on, it was apparent Michael wasn't going to share. So Shane needed to focus on making sure he was at his peak when test time came.

"Okay," Shane agreed. "We'll try again tomorrow."

\* \* \*

Vince released a blast of heat into the concrete wall, creating a focused pillar of flame between himself and the boundary. In the corner of the training room was an ever growing pile of Sterno cans, adding an even more decrepit ambiance to the seared room. Vince had been training down here for most of his two weeks, stopping only for study, tests, food, and more fire. He'd worked hard with his heat, trying new blast patterns and ranged techniques. He'd focused on close combat as well, driving up the temperature around him to near intolerable levels for any human who passed through it. His body was

sore, sweat poured from him constantly, and some of his muscles felt like a bat had been taken to them.

Vince couldn't remember a time he'd felt better. He released the bolt of flame from the wall and cupped his hands. Between his palms a fireball formed, swirled about until he threw his arms forward. The fireball launched into the wall and spread across it, leaving a swath of fresh scorches in its path.

Vince paused to pick a new target area and realized that he was more or less out of clean space to hit. They were going to have to do a hell of a job fixing up this combat room. Then again, Vince had faith there was an efficient process in place for such things; otherwise there was no way this school could function with people like himself in it. He picked up a water bottle at his feet and took a deep drink.

Tomorrow was his down day, the night of the festivities. The day after that was the exam. He still didn't feel ready, not completely, but Vince had been around the block enough times to know that he never would. He would do the best he could to prepare and then things would just play out. He wouldn't know if he was ready or not or until it was all over, because that's when the results would dictate the answer.

In the meantime, Vince still had a few hours before dinner with Sasha. The air around him seemed to be rippling as the temperature was strong-armed upward. The water bottle at his feet began to melt into the grey stone floor. Vince trained his eyes on a heavily scorched section of wall. Well, if he couldn't measure his progress by marking, he'd have to measure it by melting.

Vince stepped forward and let fly with everything he had.

## 138.

Vince wandered into the common room to find Hershel and Alice already watching television on the couch. All three were clad in pajamas, though Alice's were a pink silk set and Vince's were composed of a tank top and sweats. Hershel, on the other hand, was sporting an enormous t-shirt and a pair of work-out shorts. It was definitely dead day, a day in which lounging was not only encouraged, it was downright mandatory.

"Morning," Vince said.

"Hey," Hershel replied.

"Hi, Vince," Alice said.

"Anything good on the tube?"

"Nah," Hershel said, changing the channel. "Just some wildfires out in southern California they're trying to get under control. Interesting story, but once you've seen one clip of trees on fire you've kind of seen them all."

"Too bad," Vince said. "I know the HCP carnival thing doesn't start until around six tonight. I've been spending so much time training I'm not sure how to kill a day off."

"Ooooh, we could go into town and do some shopping," Alice suggested.

Vince and Hershel stared at her, their eyes unblinking.

"Screw you both. I'm a girl, I'm allowed to like shopping."

"I'll give you that," Vince agreed. "But we're boys. We're allowed to really not like it."

"Would you rather we let Nick organize another movie gore-a-thon?"

"The lady makes a point," Hershel conceded. "I'm scared we'll be seeing more than enough gore for my tastes tomorrow."

"It won't be that bad. We had to fight each other at the beginning of the year, and there were matches all through the first semester. Not to mention, we also had our daily sparring. I think the coaches have a good sense of what they're doing and won't let anyone get seriously hurt," Vince assured him.

"That's easy for you to say, you're smart enough to quit when you

can't win. That's a trait my alter ego lacks," Hershel said.

"I think you give me too much credit," Vince said.

"Oh, you'll both be fine," Alice snipped. "Remember, you two have actual powers. I just float."

"It served you pretty well in the semester final. You outlasted both of us," Vince pointed out.

"Not to mention it saved Nick's life on the mountain."

"Ah yes, what on earth was I thinking with that one?" Alice asked aloud.

"That we had a friend in need," Vince said, giving her a smile and plopping down in a chair near the couch. "It's kind of weird, though, you know?"

"That I saved Nick?"

"No, I mean being here, at the end of the year," Vince said. "Thinking back to how things were at the beginning, it feels like so much has changed."

"True," Alice said. "I was terrified of living next to a telepath. Now Mary is a dear friend."

"Roy was completely unmanageable. Now he's... well, still pretty unmanageable, but at least he's motivated to put in effort," Hershel said.

"I was so scared of my power I went into the initial test with nothing more than a single lighter's worth of energy," Vince said.

"How much do you have now?" Hershel asked.

"About two and a half," Vince replied.

"Oh yeah, the world is completely flipped on its head," Hershel chuckled.

Vince shrugged. "I'm just not one to take unnecessary risks."

"So some things haven't changed," Alice said. "That's a bit reassuring."

"Just weird to imagine, if this is how different things are after one year, imagine what it will be like after four," Vince mused.

"I think that's the entire point of the HCP. Bringing us from Supers we

started as and radically changing us into Heroes,” Hershel said.

“Yeah, except for the whole ‘starting as Supers’ part of it,” Alice said.

“We were Supers when the school year started. It counts,” Hershel replied.

“Very true. And given how many years of practice everyone else had on us, it’s amazing we’ve all hung in this long,” Vince said.

“I don’t know, I think being Powered for so long gave us an edge over the rest of them,” Hershel said.

“And that is?” Alice asked.

“We know what it is like to lose. We know what it is like to not be the cream of the crop or the top of the class. We’ve spent most of our lives considered pariahs while they were hailed as demigods. Long story short, we had vastly more motivation to work for the Hero title than the rest of them.”

“I can see that,” Vince agreed. “With a few exceptions. Shane is certainly one determined Super.”

“Credit where it’s due, Chad is a pretty relentless guy as well,” Hershel admitted.

“Yeah, what is that guy’s deal?” Alice asked. “I mean, I rarely ever see him smile, or laugh, or do anything besides train.”

“He and Roy trained together for a while. I can’t say for sure, but I got a strong impression that whatever his motivation is, it had something to do with his father,” Hershel said.

“Eh, who isn’t at least a little messed up from their parents?” Alice said. “Anyway, gents, we’ve strayed from the main point of this conversation.”

“How different things are?” Vince asked.

“No, figuring out what the shit we’re going to do until tonight,” Alice said.

“I have all my Dungeons and Dragons books,” Hershel volunteered softly.

“Let’s table that as Plan B,” Alice said.

“You have a Plan A?” Vince asked.

“Did you miss the whole ‘let’s go shopping’ thing?”

Vince and Hershel groaned together.

“We could get some of the others together and see what they think,” Hershel said.

Alice shook her head. “They’re as bad at this as we are. By then Nick will be up and we’ll all just go along with whatever asinine activity he pitches.”

“Someone call?” Nick said, walking in to the room.

“We were just going over our plans for the dead day,” Vince said.

“Oh, don’t worry about that,” Nick said. “It turns out there is a *Skull Splitter* marathon at the Cineplex downtown. They start with the original *Skull Splitter* and go all the way through *Skull Splitter 5: Daughter of Son of Skull Splitter*.”

Vince and Hershel cast glances at Alice, hoping against hope she had come up with some idea in the last ten seconds that would deliver them from this terrible fate.

“As much fun as that sounds, we’ve already come up with a way to burn the day,” Alice said.

“Oh did you?” Nick asked.

“Yup,” Alice confirmed. “So Hershel, go get your books.”

“Really?”

Alice looked at his excited face, then at Nick’s cocky grin, then back at Hershel.

“Really.”

## 139.

“Holy crap,” Alice said, her eyes taking in the full array of festivities. Mr. Transport had just dropped off the five Melbrook students in the central area underground, which wore a significantly different look than its usual cold stone veneer. Instead there were bright colors hanging from the ceiling in the form of streamers. Large pictures of famous Heroes had been hung along the walls, and several oversized signs directed the students to different locales within the area.

“A midway?” Nick said, skeptically reading one such sign aloud. “I thought they were kidding about the games.”

“Evidently not,” Hershel said. He was dressed more nicely than usual, a collar on his shirt and slacks rather than jeans. The lovely girl whose hand he was holding, Mary, obviously, was also adorned in a slightly fancier fashion. The two of them had decided to treat this evening like a date night since it was quite possibly the last one they would have before summer break. That was, of course, ignoring the possibility that one of them might not be invited back after the semester’s end.

“I don’t know about you guys, but I’m supposed to meet Sasha in the dancing area,” Vince said. He was also wearing a collared shirt, though his pants were still of the blue jean persuasion.

“Dancing, and I’m sure with a DJ no less,” Nick sighed. “So much for life after high school.”

“Actually, I think it’s kind of nice,” Mary said. “A lot of us didn’t get very normal high school experiences, being Supers in a school full of humans. This is a good fill in for some of the things we missed.”

“That’s one way to look at it,” Nick said. “You go find your girl, Vince. I’m off to check out the games.”

“Count me in with you,” Alice said. “I’d be more comfortable throwing ping pong balls at fish than huddling around a punch table.”

“What about you guys?” Vince turned to Hershel and Mary.

“I think we’ll take the punch table,” Hershel said, not quite controlling his idiotic grin. He couldn’t help himself; it was impossible not to be smile-happy when he had such a wonderful girl on his arm. Had Mary been listening to his thoughts, she would have blushed. Then again, had Mary been listening to many people’s thoughts, things certainly would have played out



very differently that night.

“Okay then, we’ll catch up to you later,” Vince said. He gave Alice and Nick a perfunctory wave and headed off toward the gym where the dance area was set up. Hershel and Mary followed suit, though not before Mary shot a sly, knowing look at Alice.

\* \* \*

The gym hardly seemed to be the same place as the temple of sweat and pain the students had toiled in throughout the year. Instead there was a series of refreshment tables, paper lanterns hanging from the ceiling, and an impressive sound system woofing from the walls. This controlled noise was directed from a small booth near the corner, currently manned by a junior in a grey uniform. The occasional authority figure, be it Dean Blaine, Coach George, or an adult none of the freshman recognized, dotted the landscape. They were experts at blending in, making their presence known only in the capacity that they existed, not in that they intended to interfere in the night’s revelry. It was, in truth, a little overly high school for the maturity level of the attendees, but it resounded with many just the same and the overall spirit could be described as boisterous.

One such cheerful soul was Vince as he scooped up Sasha into a spinning hug, the outer layer of her bright pink skirt (it matched the tips of her hair) was sent twirling about behind her. They kissed briefly and Vince set her back to the ground. The music was loud enough that talking was possible, if a bit uncomfortable. Fortunately, Vince and Sasha had little to say that required words. They looked into each other’s eyes as her feet made contact with the floor and she kissed him again. This one was less brief.

It didn’t take long before the rest of their friends had clustered around them. Will, Jill, Stella, Violet, and Thomas seemed to have all come as a singular unit. Alex surprised everyone, introducing them to his date for the evening: Selena. Her caramel skin looked all the deeper against the deep green of her dress and her long hair had been styled up expertly with just a few wisps left hanging down. Vince gave his friend a questioning look, which was met with a shrug and a smile as if to say, “Beats me how I pulled it off.” Vince laughed and squeezed the hand of his own date. The group stayed clustered for only a short while before giving in to the inevitable expression of high spirits and close friends.

They found their way to the dance floor and began to make utter fools of themselves. Limbs thrashed about, rhythm became a poor, downtrodden concept, and endorphins surged through their veins. In the shadows their

supervisors smiled. Despite the harsh nature of the program, those selected to teach the HCP genuinely enjoyed the education process. One perk of that process was this time every year, when they got to see the young, happy sides of their charges, not the hardened warriors they were sculpting them into. It was both rewarding and heartbreaking, because each teacher knew that most would lose the ability to act so carefree. Probably by this time next year.

Another set of eyes watched the dancers, though these were not filled with such kind-hearted sentiments. No, these eyes were calculating and hard, but nearly brimming over with excitement. These eyes told the story of retribution long denied that was on the cusp of being unfurled. For the moment, all they did was watch. This moment had been so long in the making that there was no need to rush. It needed to be perfect, because the owner of those eyes had a feeling he would be savoring it for years to come.

## 140.

The various classrooms that dotted the underground area had been filled with carnival-style games of chance for the delight of those who considered themselves too refined for such frivolity as dancing. The music from the gym could still be heard thanks to a well-connected (but thankfully low in volume) PA system with speakers at each corner. Grey-uniformed middle classmen were tasked with manning the various booths, serving as free labor as well as a control should some of the youngsters get rowdy.

“This is ultra-lame,” Nick complained as he and Alice meandered the halls. “I mean, seriously, dart throwing? Haven’t we all spent, like, the past couple of months training in ranged combat?”

“I think it’s quaint,” Alice disagreed. “It’s a reminder of the normal world. It’s easy to get so caught up in all this that you forget what it’s like for the rest of the humans. Or the rest of the Supers, for that matter. I have trouble remembering a time when the HCP didn’t seem to dominate a majority of my life. This is a pleasant break.”

“Yeah, except that for some people that break might be a bit more permanent than they’d like,” Nick said.

Alice looked at him, trying in vain to see past the sunglasses into the eyes that lurked behind them. “Worried?”

“Just aware. Not everyone makes the cut, and I’m not exactly a ranked combatant. There’s nothing wrong with a little focus.”

“Pfft, a little focus my butt,” Alice said. “This from the guy who spent the entire two weeks of training watching television on the couch.”

“It was a part of my training regiment,” Nick replied.

“Only if you’re training for a bad sitcom trivia game show.”

“And the lady has uncovered my backup plan if the HCP doesn’t work out.”

“Uh huh, whatever you say there, slick,” Alice huffed. “I’m sure you have some secret scheme to slide through these tests with a passing grade. In the meantime, there’s a more pressing matter facing you.”

“What’s that?”

Alice pointed at a game some yards down the hall.

“They have giant bears and you are going to win one for me.”

“Why would I do that?”

“Because I’m not above guilting you into dancing with me and then stomping on your feet all night.”

Nick sighed. “A bear for the lady it is then.”

\* \* \*

As time slipped by, the group dancing gave way to the inevitable coupling up of partners. Vince and Sasha were the first to slip off, followed not long after by Alex and Selena, then Hershel and Mary. Thomas did double duty, switching between Violet and Stella as dance partner at their whims. Stella would never admit it but she, along with several other girls, wished it was Roy making an appearance tonight instead of Hershel. They were hard out of luck, though, because with all the training and prep work Roy had been putting in for the test, it had been no contest giving this night over to Hershel. Besides, Mary had been very adamant that she get to spend the night with the boy she was actually dating and the wagers of their bet still held effect for the next two days.

Hershel noticed Alice and Nick wandering into the gym area, Alice clutching an oversized plush bear, as he and Mary stepped into the hallway to get a little space. This is where several of the games had been set up; however, there were also several classrooms left open, presumably for the purpose of those who wanted to get away from the racket for a while. It was in one of these that the duo found themselves resting after the better part of an hour they had spent kicking up the dance floor.

“Woo,” Mary said and she plopped down. “I have no idea how some girls do that in heels.”

“Practice?” Hershel ventured.

“I’d rather do a Coach George workout than practice that,” Mary said, shaking her head. “No question about it, I’m a flats girl.”

“I didn’t know that point had ever come up for debate,” Hershel said.

“It hasn’t. I’m just putting it out there preemptively, lest you expect me to start donning pumps on special occasions.”

“So you see us celebrating special occasions together then, I take it?”

“Well, yeah,” Mary said. Her eyes fluttered downward and an

unfamiliar blush crept into her cheeks. “I mean, you and I are sort of... well, I mean, you’re my boyfriend, aren’t you?”

“I’d hoped so, but I never really wanted to press the issue,” Hershel admitted, a tomato coloration rising in his own face.

Mary giggled nervously. “You and I aren’t very good at this, are we?”

“Doesn’t look that way,” Hershel agreed. “I mean, we’ve been dating for a few months now, and I’m really enjoying it.”

“As am I.”

“And there isn’t really anyone else I want to be dating.”

“I’ll second that motion as well,” Mary said.

“So then, yes, I think we are in fact in a relationship.”

“You certain? I bet we can get a second opinion,” Mary offered.

“Nope, no need. I’m calling it officially. I am your boyfriend and vice versa,” Hershel declared.

“Well, when you say it with so much confidence, I don’t know how I can refuse.” The two had scooted closer during the conversation. Now they were locked into each other’s eyes, idiotic smiles splitting their faces and a slow twitch of nerves jerking through their skin.

“We are ridiculous,” Hershel said.

“But adorable,” Mary tacked on.

They leaned in and kissed, their first one since taking the next step forward in the relationship. It was familiar, scary, awkward, and overrun with joy.

It, along with the sharp crackle of electricity, was also their last conscious memory for the next several hours.

\* \* \*

“Where’d the happy couple go to?” Nick asked as the music dimmed in volume. The DJ could be seen evacuating his booth in pursuit of a bathroom and a fresh water bottle, so dancing was tabled for the duration of his break.

“Off away from all these prying eyes,” Sasha theorized. “A sentiment I can get behind, if you know what I mean.” In case anyone didn’t know what

she meant, Sasha took the opportunity to slap Vince firmly on the ass.

“I’m sure they just wanted to talk in private,” Vince said, eyes darting about as he searched inwardly for any strategy to hide his fresh embarrassment. Sadly, he found no such method: Vince had always been cursed with wearing the truth on his face.

“On that note, though, Alex and Selena seem to have left, too,” Thomas pointed out.

“I saw her slip out with him a few songs ago,” Violet said. “I’m going to go out on a limb and say they were definitely not just heading out to talk.”

“Alex and Selena, huh? When, and more importantly how, did that happen?” Nick asked.

There was a collective shrug. “They hung out a lot during the river trip,” Stella said. “I guess they found a connection.”

“Huh. Kudos to him, that girl is crazy hot. A toast to our buddy scoring some out-of-his-league tail,” Nick said, snatching up a few punch glasses from the table and handing them out.

“How about we just cheers to a great year instead?” Vince offered.

“Whatever,” Nick said by way of agreement. The friends clinked glasses and downed the cherry-flavored drink. A crackle from overhead indicated the DJ booth speaker was about to be used.

“I’m sorry to interrupt your fun,” said a new voice, half-strangled with its own excitement. “However, I’ve recently discovered some information that the entire HCP needs to be alerted to.”

Nick felt the muscles in lower back tense immediately.

“I just thought it should be known that despite what they have told us, the entire Melbrook populace - Nicholas Campbell, Alice Adair, Hershel Daniels, Mary Smith, and Vince Reynolds - are not Supers. They’re all Powereds. And I have proof.”

## 141.

“Sounds like somebody spiked their own punch,” Nick quipped, attitude cavalier and brain slammed into overdrive. His eyes swept the room at a fevered pace, thankfully hidden by the tinted frames as he assessed their situation. Despite what years of television had conditioned one to believe, the shocking announcement was not met with immediate riots. It was instead greeted with confusion as uncertainty rippled through the crowd. Some of the students were looking at the DJ booth, trying to figure out who had broken in to make such a strange declaration. Others were talking amongst themselves, likely trying to figure out who all those names belonged to. The Melbrook students did, after all, only account for a small segment of the freshmen class, so they were not household names. It seemed some of the adults were making beelines for the booth, no doubt in attempt to find out exactly what was going on and regain control of it. All of which were factors Nick could have handled. The problem was, as it often is, with the people they counted as friends. Thomas, Stella, Violet, Will, and Jill were all staring at him, Alice, and Vince. Sasha was still holding her boyfriend’s hand, though her body language made it clear she was uncertain how to feel about such a strange declaration.

“No kidding,” Alice said. “I mean, I know stress is high, but that seems like a strange prank to try and pull.”

Nick could have kissed that girl. She might not have been the world’s best liar, but growing up around businessmen and diplomats had given her some acumen. Not to mention she was smart enough to follow the leader when the time was right.

“That does seem strange,” Sasha said. “Right, Vince?”

“Twelve years ago a Vegas paper called *The Strip Beat* ran a story about the collapse of a local restaurant, cause of which was ultimately determined to be a young Powered boy by the name of Nicholas Campbell,” the voice said over the crackling PA system.

“Sure, he can claim a fake news story, but did he go to the trouble of making a fake paper as well? You know that’s where the quality of a prank is determined: in the details,” Nick said.

“Aren’t you from Vegas, though?” Thomas asked.

“A fact that is readily available to anyone in our class,” Nick replied.

“This is really stupid, isn’t it, Vince?” Sasha asked again.

“Three years ago there was a police report filed against a Powered named Roy Daniels for underage drinking and destruction of property,” the voice continued. “Eight years ago there was a search ordered for a Powered named Alice Adair who floated out of the garden on a spring afternoon. And then there are the literally dozens reports of a young silver-haired homeless child shorting out and inadvertently destroying thousands of dollars in property across the country. All of which I have documentation of, along with locations of the original sources, in the booth with me.”

The tide of the crowd was turning. While initially they’d been waiting for a punch line to the gag, it was becoming evident that whoever had hijacked the booth intended to be taken seriously. That shifted the tone of the announcement greatly. Nick noticed more and more stares turning toward him and his dorm mates as identification was made and skepticism gave way to suspicion.

“While I enjoy a good witch hunt as much as the next guy, it is a lot less fun when you’re the one with a wart on your nose. Maybe we’d best take our leave until they settle that joker down,” Nick said, scanning the room for the nearest exit back to the lifts.

“No, there’s no need for you guys to go,” Thomas said. “Just because someone is making baseless accusations it shouldn’t ruin our night.”

“That’s right. Some guy is just being an asshole. There’s no way you guys could have lied to us all year. Right, Vince?” This time Sasha was practically pleading, her months spent with Vince allowing her to see the truth in his face and his silence before the others noticed. While Nick and Alice might be playing it off well, the guilt of having lived a falsehood for so long had suddenly crashed down upon Vince’s shoulders. His face was a tapestry of shame. As Nick looked at his friend the strategy immediately changed. There was no chance for damage control. The only course of action now was an immediate exit.

“I’m sorry,” Vince said softly, his eyes drawn to the floor rather than face Sasha.

“Alice, get the hell out of here,” Nick whispered.

“What about Hershel and Mary?”

“The whole place is wired for sound, I’m sure they heard our outing. Plus, Mary is a telepath, so if she’s listening to any of us she’ll know we’re making tracks,” Nick assured her. “Now hurry your ass up. Vince and I will



be right behind you.”

Without another word Alice slunk off through the crowd, the giant stuffed bear acting as a buoy to mark her location.

Nick stepped forward and wrapped his hand around Vince’s arm. “Come on, buddy, I think we should get out of here while the air gets cleared. We don’t want anything bad to happen over some silly misunderstanding.”

“What do you mean you’re sorry?” Sasha asked, pulling her hand free of her and Vince’s shared clasp.

“I mean... I never meant to lie to you, Sasha,” Vince said. Though the words were meant only for her, the meaning was not lost of the rest of their friends. Nick saw shock, then uncertainty ripple through their faces. He knew it was only a short jump before that turned into anger and betrayal, so he dug his fingernails into Vince’s arm and pulled him close.

“Vince, if you have ever trusted in me or our friendship at all, then for the love of shit come with me right fucking now,” Nick said, abandoning all pretense and dragging his friend toward the exit.

“What about the others?”

“All taken care of. They’ll meet us at the dorm,” Nick told him.

“I meant our friends and classmates.”

Nick sucked in a tight breath through his teeth. “Vince, if we stay here I can just about promise you we won’t have any of those left when they’re done with us. We need to regroup in a safe place. Now stop dragging your fucking feet and hustle.”

“You’re sure this is the right move?” Vince’s big blues were wide and scared. The kid might be hell in a fight but he didn’t know to deal with things like subterfuge and discovery. He needed guidance and he was trusting Nick to provide it to him. To put him on the right path in this time of tribulation.

“Absolutely, things will be fine” Nick lied. “But we can’t be here when they find out that guy is telling the truth and the room hits a fever pitch. We get safe, we let things cool off, and we fix whatever is still broken when the dust settles.”

“Okay,” Vince said with a nod, finally picking up the pace as he and Nick cleared an exit at the south end of the room. Once they were out of the gym they broke into a flat out sprint down the halls until they hit the lifts. Alice was already in place, and as soon as they crossed the threshold she

flipped the switch, sending them slowly back upwards to the real world.

## 142.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport were enjoying a quiet cup of tea in the kitchen when they heard the front door slam open loudly. They exchanged a wary glance and Mr. Numbers tensed momentarily as a flood of possible attack scenarios played out in his head. Their concern was (briefly) alleviated when the voices of their charges reached their location. That reprieve lasted only until they ascertained of context of said discussion.

“Didn’t you see their faces? They aren’t going to forgive us,” Alice’s voice declared from the living room.

“They’re our friends. They’ll understand why we had to keep it a secret,” Vince disagreed.

“Forgive us? Are you two joking or just playing dumb?” Nick berated. “Do you not realize the full scope of what this outing means? Forget feelings of betrayal from our friends, that shit is nothing. We’re Poweredreds that have become and functioned as Supers in the HCP for an entire school year. Our existence challenges everything they know about the distinction between Supers and Poweredreds. Trust me, when that realization really sets in we’re looking at a lot of trouble. I’ll be amazed if they don’t have this house burned down by morning.”

Mr. Transport’s eyes had grown larger throughout Nick’s tirade. By the time it ended his eyes could have passed as twins to the saucer currently resting under his teacup. He and Mr. Numbers exchanged another look, this time fully aware of the situation and taking up their respective roles for how to deal with it. Mr. Numbers made an immediate exit into their room, shutting the door firmly behind him. Mr. Transport took one last sip of his tea and stepped out into the living room.

“It won’t be that bad,” Alice said. “I mean, what do they care if Poweredreds can get control of their abilities? It doesn’t stop all the Supers from having theirs.”

“Alice, there are about nearly double the number of Poweredreds in the world as there are Supers. Poweredreds who have spent their whole lives being looked down on, belittled, and treated as second-class citizens. Poweredreds who, for all they know, will be turning into Supers with a pretty justified grudge by year’s end. How do you see that playing out? Because I promise you, they’re assuming the worst-case scenario,” Nick said.

“But that’s not going to happen,” Vince pointed out. “We’re the only

ones.”

“What’s true doesn’t matter. Only what they’re afraid of is relevant,” Nick replied.

“I’m afraid Nick has a point,” Mr. Transport said.

“They’re going to burn the house down?” Vince asked.

“Not necessarily. But he is correct in that things will be getting worse before they get better,” Mr. Transport clarified. “This revelation will need to be handled carefully, and the public delicately managed. They will make peace with it, though. Eventually.”

“What can we do to help?” Vince asked, taking a step forward.

“At the moment, with things as uncertain as they are, the only thing we need from you is to stay safe. I’ll be extracting you all to a safe location once Mr. Numbers determines the optimum place for us to use,” Mr. Transport said.

“Wait, you don’t already know where we’re going?” Alice asked, a new flavor of fear pungent in her voice.

“No, but I assure you it will only take us a short while to make the determination,” Mr. Transport said.

“Yeah, that’s great, but if you don’t know where you’re taking us then I’m guessing you didn’t already take Hershel and Mary there,” Alice said.

“That would be a correct guess,” Mr. Transport agreed.

“Then where are they?” Alice asked. “We got slowed down by worming through all the people out celebrating the end of finals on campus, crowds Mary could detect and avoid with her telepathy. They should have easily beaten us here, but they didn’t. So where are they?”

“Excuse me,” said a new voice, one soft and female. “The door was open so I...”

Mr. Transport and the three students whirled on their feet at the intruder, only to find one of the HCP freshmen girls looking awkward in the doorway.

“I’m sorry, young lady, but this is not an opportune time for visiting,” Mr. Transport said briskly.

“I know. I mean, obviously. I mean, I was underground and everything

and heard the announcement,” she said. “But there’s something I really need to tell you guys.”

Nick gave her a brief nod.

“Then you better say it quick, because I think this place is going to empty pretty soon.”

“Right, um, so, my name is Agatha, and I’m in class with you guys,” Agatha said. “But I mean, you knew that, I’m the only animator in our year. Anyway, I know none of us really hang out or talk or anything, but over spring break Mary helped me out when I was stuck in the library so I know she’s a really nice girl and I guess we’re kind of friends. So I was using my power to just sort of eavesdrop on everyone tonight with some folded paper figures.”

“Not to be rude, but I trust there’s a point coming around the bend,” Nick said.

“There is. I had one hanging out in an empty classroom when Hershel and Mary walked in. I was going to have him leave but then they started talking and it was really sweet, so I kept listening in. And that’s why my creation was still around to see what happened,” Agatha said. She took in a deep breath and stared miserably at the floor. She wasn’t one for speaking to groups of people, and this was going to be hardest part to tell.

“They were knocked out and taken.”

“They were *what*?” Vince yelled, his back jerking straight as a flagpole and his hand curling into fists.

“What? No, no, no, that’s crazy,” Alice said, aggressive denial setting in. “I don’t believe it. This is a horrible joke to play on tonight of all nights.”

“Both of you shut up,” Nick said, not quite raising his voice to yell, but projecting loud enough overwhelm them both. He stepped toward Agatha, taking in every last detail about the girl. The angle of her eyes, the position of her feet, the wrinkling around her eyebrow, not one piece of it escaped Nick’s focus. This was unfortunate, because it all pointed to a single conclusion.

“She’s telling the truth,” Nick announced. “But there’s something I don’t understand. Hershel might be powerless in his normal form, but Mary is a juggernaut. Who could have subdued both of them without causing a ruckus and then slipped them out of the gym?”

Agatha somehow managed to look even more uncomfortable as she

squirmed in place.

“That’s why I came to tell you all instead of getting a professor or the dean,” she said. “I’m really hoping there’s a logical explanation for this, but just in case there isn’t I thought you should know.”

“Tell us who took them,” Vince said. The initial panic had passed from his voice; what remained was a tone that was flat as a blade and just as sharp.

Agatha licked her lips and tried to remember the kind act of the girl she was worried about. There probably was a good reason for what she had seen, but as she remembered Mary’s unconscious body being tossed over that man’s shoulder so unceremoniously, she couldn’t think of a single one that would fully explain the situation.

“The people who took them... It was the coaches. George and Persephone.”

## 143.

“This is ridiculous,” Alice said, shaking her head. “We’re really going to believe a crazy story given to us by some girl we’ve never even talked to?”

“She was telling the truth,” Nick reiterated. He used the past tense because after her revelation Agatha had quickly excused herself. In her defense, the room had reacted somewhat less than calmly to such an accusation and only now was reason reasserting its dominance. “That doesn’t mean she really saw what she thinks she saw, but it means she believes it.”

“So then maybe she made a mistake,” Alice said hopefully. “Maybe Hershel and Mary just went somewhere on their own.”

“And turned off their phones?” Vince asked.

“I don’t know. Maybe they didn’t want to be interrupted,” Alice said, clinging desperately to the hope of her fantasy.

“I’m afraid we have to assume the girl was right,” Mr. Numbers said, walking into the room and joining the conversation.

“You heard what happened?” Vince asked.

Before Mr. Numbers could bother coming up with an explanation, Nick beat him to it with the truth.

“They constructed this whole place to monitor us, Vince; obviously the room is bugged.”

“Correct, but hardly the most pressing matter at the moment,” Mr. Numbers said, ending the conversation on ethics before it could even begin. Though normally such a discovery would undoubtedly hurt the goodwill his charges held toward him and Mr. Transport, at present Mr. Numbers would rank it as a “non-concern.”

“Hershel and Mary’s phones were both dumped in a trash can near the edge of campus,” Mr. Numbers said. “There are also tracking chips in some of their pieces of clothing, and in their bodies, all of which I’ve confirmed seem to have been disabled. Whoever orchestrated this abduction had a tremendous level of skill and a high level of knowledge regarding the safety procedures we put in place to deal with situations just like this one. I’m afraid both of the coaches fall into that category.”

“Wait, you bugged our bodies?”

“Priorities, Miss Adair. There will be able time for you to mourn your violated privacy at a later date. Right now we have two of your group confirmed as abducted and no idea if the rest of you are being targeted for a similar attempt,” Mr. Numbers chastised her. He turned his attention to Mr. Transport. “I’ve spoken with our home office and we are going into an immediate lockdown. They will be sending an enforcer as additional protection until a safe extraction point is determined. He will arrive within the hour.”

“And what about Hershel and Mary?” Vince asked. “What’s the plan to help them?”

“We have been tasked with ensuring the safety of you, our remaining charges,” Mr. Numbers said, several degrees of cold forced into his voice. “I’m not certain what efforts will be undertaken to reclaim your friends, but I do know that we are not going to be part of it.”

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport looked at each other. They both knew their role in the company. If home office wasn’t sending their team after the abductees, then it meant no one was going after them. The company had decided to protect the three it had rather than chase the two it lost, and it was sending down a representative to make certain the orders were complied with.

“No,” Vince said, shaking his head. “We’re going after them.”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” Mr. Numbers said. “You have no idea how to find them.”

“There has to be a way,” Vince replied with a shrug. “I’ll find it.”

“That is not a plan, that is a slapdash idea that will culminate in nothing more than putting yourself at risk by leaving a safe environment,” Mr. Numbers countered.

“I don’t care. I won’t sit around while my friends are in trouble,” Vince said. “Though I’ll admit I’m out of my depth and welcome your help.”

“Ludicrous; we have our orders and we are complying with them,” Mr. Numbers said.

Mr. Transport, on the other hand, stepped toward Vince and softened his voice to a kinder tone, as if in hopes of reasoning with the boy.

“Vince, you need to think about what you’re saying. Even if you could find them, what would you do when you caught up? Coach George is much stronger than you, and Persephone has ample cunning to go with power.”



“No question about it,” Vince agreed. “But I won’t be alone. I’ll have Alice and Nick. Besides, I don’t have to beat them. I just have to keep them busy long enough to make sure everyone gets away.”

“What does that accomplish? You’d just be trading in your own freedom for theirs,” Mr. Transport pointed out.

“Yes. I would,” Vince agreed. “Though I doubt it would come to that. The coaches could have taken any of us. If they took those two then it is because they’re the ones they wanted.”

Mr. Transport stared at the boy for a long moment. He’d been in charge of these kids for nearly a year now and he’d seen them change and grow so much in that short time. Mr. Transport still remembered Vince on that first day, so awkward and uncertain in how to handle himself. The boy had gotten comfortable here, but the one thing he’d never truly overcome was that lingering fear about his power. It tainted everything he did, colored his own confidence and how he carried himself through life. There was no fear in his eyes right now, though, only a relentless drive to act. Looking at those eyes, Mr. Transport realized the only way he was going to stop Vince was to knock him unconscious, and even then he wasn’t one hundred percent sure the boy’s body wouldn’t keep crawling toward the door.

“We’ll help you,” Mr. Transport said.

“We most certainly will not,” Mr. Numbers disagreed. “Mr. Transport, do I need to remind you that-”

“Enough, Luke!” Mr. Transport said, whipping his head toward his partner and raising his voice. “They took our fucking kids. Mary and Hershel, the students we’ve watched over and we’ve said we were responsible for. We said we would protect them and that rat son-of-a-bitch snatched them right out from under us.”

“While I understand your attachment, there is no need to let emotion cloud our judgment,” Mr. Numbers said, his voice remaining perfectly even. “We have our orders and we will comply with them.”

Mr. Transport scooped something off the coffee table in a fluid motion and strode over to his partner. When he next spoke, his voice was no longer raised; instead it was a whisper with the intensity of a deathbed confession.

“They took our kids. I’m not the company and I’m not some stranger. Don’t pull the automaton act with me. I know you aren’t unfeeling. I know you’re pissed off. I know you’re aware that no one else is going to help them.”

“They are not ‘our kids’, Mr. Transport. They are just our latest assignment. An assignment that has been altered.”

“Sure they aren’t,” Mr. Transport said. He slapped his right hand into Mr. Numbers’ own palm, pressing the object he’d nabbed from the table into the shorter man’s flesh.

Mr. Numbers turned his hand up slowly, revealing the white king from the chess set resting between his fingers.

“They took Mary and Hershel. And the company is just going to let them go.”

“We have spent our lives as loyal employees. How do you recommend we even go about the act of committing treason against our handlers?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“Easy. With a whole lot of lying,” Mr. Transport replied.

“You’re sure you want to do this?” Mr. Numbers asked.

“I am.”

“We don’t have long before the enforcer arrives.”

“Then we’ll move fast.”

Mr. Numbers curled his fingers around the chess piece, grasping it tightly in the ball of his fist.

“I’ll go talk to the other half,” Mr. Numbers said.

“I’ll drop you off in a moment,” Mr. Transport said, giving his partner a brief smile. He turned to address the others, who had been watching their hushed exchange with growing trepidation.

“We can’t do much, but we’ll help,” Mr. Transport announced.

“Thank you,” Vince said. “With all of us working together I know we can help our friends.”

“Yeah, just one problem with that,” Nick chimed in, taking a few steps away from the other two. “You guys can have fun riding up and playing cowboy, but my ass is out of here.”

## 144.

“That’s not funny, Nick,” Alice chided him.

“I’m not joking,” Nick told her. Gone was his usual smirk and taunting tone. Instead his face was pinched and serious, coated with more gravity than any of the dorm’s residents could remember seeing before. “I’ll stay until we get the all clear, and then I’m going back to Vegas.”

“But our friends are in trouble,” Vince said.

“Your friends, Vince,” Nick corrected. “In case you missed the big reveal downstairs, our cover just got blown. Now, while you and Mary and probably Roy can all still get by after being outed, my only shot was to fly under the radar. The blowing of the whistle on us signaled the end of my career at Lander.”

“That doesn’t change the fact that Mary and Hershel need us, though,” Alice jumped in.

Nick laughed, a hard and bitter sound instead of usual robust chuckles.

“What part of this aren’t you getting? I’m leaving. That means I’m done with this whole facade. I’m not risking my neck to save those two because it’s not my problem. They mean nothing to me, and I no longer have to pretend otherwise.”

“I don’t understand,” Vince said slowly. “You’re our friend, a fellow former Powered. You’re one of us.”

“No, Vince, I’m just a great liar who wanted to learn as much about his abilities as he could,” Nick told him, something that might have been gentleness leaking into his voice. “Nothing personal; the day our secret came out was always going to be my exit. I just needed a group of allies to use during my time here.”

“I don’t believe you,” Vince said simply.

“I didn’t expect you to,” Nick said, half a smile twitching across his face.

“You’ll come help us. I know you will,” Vince told him, patting him on the shoulder. “I have to go get ready for the fight, but I have faith you’ll reach the right decision. There’s more to you than you think.”

Without another word Vince walked away, past Mr. Numbers and Mr.

Transport who were furtively whispering in their own corner, content to let the students resolve their own problems while the duo tackled logistics of the rescue effort.

“Same old Vince,” Nick said, shaking his head. He turned to Alice. “Are you going to give you a cute little speech too?”

“No,” Alice said softly. “I just want to know something. You’re saying you were lying this entire time? About everything?”

“Sorry, Alice, but yes. I guess on the plus side I can finally admit your suspicions of my duplicitous nature were right. Kudos; you’re the only non-telepath one who caught on.”

“I guess I was,” Alice said. Nick expected a lot of things to follow. He was braced for tears, accusations, pleas, or even yelling. Unfortunately he was not braced for the right hook Alice deftly slammed into his face. There was an audible CRACK and a muffled thudding as Nick fell to the floor, his hands racing up to cover the eyes Alice had punched. Nearby his sunglasses tumbled to the ground as well, cleaved neatly in two by the blow with the left eye’s lens spinning to a stop some feet away.

“What the *fuck*?” Nick demanded from his prone position on the floor.

“You lied to us, you manipulated us, you want to abandon us, and you’re surprised I hit you? I thought you were supposed to be smart!” Alice shook her hand in pain with as much subtlety as she could muster, trying not to let her eyes tear up from a potent mixture of injury, outrage, and betrayal.

“I did what I had to in order to get by,” Nick spat at her.

“Bullshit. You could have gotten by on your own if you were so determined to stay alone. You didn’t have to be the bastard who makes people trust him only to bail when things get hard. You didn’t have to let us think we could... care.” Alice stared down at the boy she had spent so much of the year fighting with, pining after, verbally sparring with, and finding comfort in. And much as she hated herself for it, a part of her still wanted to offer him a hand up from the ground.

“You know what really turns my stomach, though? That night I kissed you, I did it hoping that under the slick veneer there was actually this decent guy with good reasons for hiding himself. I thought that the man behind the mask had to be better. And now I find out that the real you is nothing but a selfish coward who won’t risk anything for people who would put it on all the line for him if things were reversed.”

“Are you done yet?” Nick asked, glaring up at her unabashedly.

“Only with you,” Alice said, spinning on her heel and walking away.

\* \* \*

Hershel’s eyes began to flutter as he came around. His first thought was wondering who had stuffed his head full of cotton. His second was to realize that probably wasn’t the case, but he was working through one hell of a groggy headache.

“I still wish we could have used the teleporter,” said a female voice, thought it sounded vaguely muffled, like it was coming through a wall.

“Wish in one hand, shit in the other,” barked back a harsh male voice. This one Hershel took only seconds to place; he’d heard far more of it, after all.

Hershel opened his eyes to see what was going on. He didn’t remember anything since kissing Mary, so he had no idea why his head hurt so bad. Or why he was apparently riding in the back of a moving truck. Or while he was handcuffed and shackled to the floor. What had been mere curiosity was quickly transitioning to apprehension.

“Looks like Sleeping Beauty is coming around,” Coach George said, giving him a smile. Hershel noticed that Mary was sitting next to him, not handcuffed but also not conscious. She had a silver mechanism wrapped around her head that he was certain hadn’t been there previously.

“Was goin’ ahn?” Hershel asked, his tongue feeling thick and slow in his mouth.

“Whew, seems like that slumber Persephone induced did a doozy on you, Daniels,” Coach George said. “I think she might have used too much. Sorry about that.”

Hershel wasn’t sure how well he could communicate verbally, so instead of trying again he looked around then raised his metal ensnared hands with a questioning look on his face.

“Ah, you want me to explain I take it?”

Hershel nodded emphatically.

“Well, Daniels, the short answer is actually pretty simple,” Coach George said with a reassuring smile. “You’re being kidnapped.”

## 145.

“Klidnapped?” Hershel mumbled, his mind comprehending but his mouth still refusing its usual duties.

“Close enough,” Coach George agreed. “Though to be honest, you’re more being brought along because you were there. Wrong place, wrong time sort of thing. There was only one of you we actually wanted.”

Hershel’s eyes flicked to Mary.

“Obviously. Process of elimination when there are only two of you isn’t that tough,” Coach George confirmed.

“Wats on hler hlead?”

“Oh, you like? It’s a subsonic neutralization... aw fuck, this thing has a really technical name but I can never remember it all. It’s a gizmo that keeps people unconscious. Very useful, but very controlled and hard to come by. Hence why you aren’t sporting one. I mean, why bother?”

“Caush I wash jusht there,” Hershel managed to spit out.

“Yes, that,” Coach George agreed. “And the more obvious reason. Mary is one of the most powerful advanced minds in recorded history, let alone at her age. Containing her awake would be hellacious, to say the least. You, on the other hand, are a fat smart kid with self-esteem issues.”

“Roy,” was all Hershel managed to get out before Coach George laughed.

“Roy? I’m sorry, do you think I’m going to be giving you any whiskey? You can’t access Roy, and that means you’re of no more concern to me than any other regular human.”

Coach George paused for a moment and regarded his conscious captive.

“It’s kind of funny, you know; back when you were just Powered, you almost certainly would have shifted by now. But without a specific trigger you’re stuck there, utterly helpless. In a way you were actually stronger back before you had any control. Ain’t that a bitch?”

Hershel made a valiant effort to spit at Coach George, but the slippery tongue and untrustworthy mouth betrayed him once more, leading to little more than a stream of droll falling from his lips. Though his cheeks burned on

instinct, his eyes continued to send daggers at Coach George's rugged, unbearably smiling face.

\* \* \*

"We have fifteen minutes," Mr. Transport announced as he returned to the room. He had left with Mr. Numbers only seconds prior, but was returning as a solo act. "At that point we will go, pick up Mr. Numbers, find out Mary and Hershel's location, drop you off, and return to meet the man coming to stop us from doing those very things."

"You won't stay and help?" Alice asked, a new dimension of fear entering her voice. Losing Nick had been worrying; losing the only two adults left in their party was an altogether terrifying development.

Mr. Transport shook his head. "Alice, try to understand. If Mr. Numbers and I are believed to have gone against company orders, then come next year not only is there zero chance of us still being here, but there will be vast repercussions for him and me both. If they just think you all got the drop on us, we might still be able to swing the same post here next year. Additionally we will be here to distract our... associate from finding you all too soon."

"Why does that matter?"

"Because his order will only be to recover you three; it won't bear regard to your friends. And he will execute his orders. Trust me," Mr. Transport said, a bit of the color slipping out of his face.

"We understand," Vince said, standing up from the sofa where he'd been resting. "So we have fifteen minutes?"

"Fourteen and a half now," Mr. Transport corrected. "Gather any tools or weapons you might favor, get dressed for combat, gather whatever you think will give you the best edge." His eyes flicked briefly to the boys' side door, which Nick had slammed ceremoniously behind himself directly after his and Alice's altercation. Alice pretended not to notice.

"Guess I'm getting out of my dress, then," she said, turning on a stiletto heel and gliding through the girls' side door.

"Vince, I assume you'll want to change out of slacks and a button-down," Mr. Transport urged.

"Of course. There's something else I need, though; something very important," Vince said slowly.

“Then go get it! This deadline is non-negotiable.”

“I’ll need your help,” Vince explained. “It isn’t exactly close at hand.”

“Fine, fine; as long as we can get it in time to get back here for Alice’s pick up I’ll take you wherever you need to go,” Mr. Transport agreed.

Vince told him the location. Mr. Transport’s already pallid coloration whitened another shade.

\* \* \*

Nick sat on his bed, staring off into space. Every now and then he would reach to adjust the sunglasses that were no longer there. Instead they rested on his desk as a pile of debris. It was no great loss; in truth he’d planned on smashing them himself once his time here at Lander had ended. He was still a bit miffed that it was that girl who had the pleasure of their destruction instead of him. Nick’s hand almost tightened in reflex to the thought of Alice and her sucker punch. He was slipping; he couldn’t believe he nearly allowed an emotion to manifest itself as a physical gesture. He’d have to put himself in some intense retraining when he got back to Vegas.

At least his planning wasn’t slipping. Nick had kept a go bag under his bed since his first day in Melbrook, a bag that was now propped up against his door. He could grab it when the rest left to go on their suicide mission and make his escape. He’d purchased and parked two vehicles other than the Bug in key locations on the Lander campus, vehicles with no record of being owned or driven by Nicholas Campbell, just in case. The windows were tinted to minimize recognition. There were toll passes to accommodate any route he might take stashed in his glove boxes.

Nick reran his mental checklist and confirmed what he already knew. That he was fore thinking, that he was intelligent, and that he planned for every possibility.

Almost.



## 146.

“Are you certain this is a good idea?” Mr. Transport asked, his voice slightly raised to be heard over the roar and crackle of the blaze.

“Honestly? Not really,” Vince admitted, his own tone at an equal volume.

The two stood about a mile away from the perimeter of a tremendous inferno, the forest fire that was currently assaulting southern California. Since that morning’s report, the ravaging flames had grown in proximity, defying the valiant attempts of local officials to bring it under control. The area had been evacuated hours ago, so Mr. Transport and Vince stood alone as they stared into the flickering heat steadily creeping toward them. Even from this distance Mr. Transport’s face was warm and his breath felt a touch smoky.

“Then perhaps we should conceive of a different plan,” Mr. Transport proposed.

Vince glanced down at his wrist watch. “We have ten minutes left. Any ideas for something we can put together and execute in that much time?”

“We could raid a camping store. You could pop the Sterno cans one by one to absorb their heat in more manageable chunks.”

Vince shook his head. “I somehow don’t think it would be quite the same effect.”

“And why exactly do you need this effect?” Mr. Transport asked. “I realize you are facing a significant challenge, but doesn’t this seem a bit like overkill?”

“None of us landed a single hit on Coach George when we fought him,” Vince told Mr. Transport. “Not even Mary or Chad. With only Alice, Nick, and me coming at him we have zero chance of winning, or even stalling long enough for one of us to recover our friends and escape.”

“I was beginning to wonder if you were aware of the realistic odds.”

“I am. I am also aware that I’m the only one of us left who was enrolled in the combat training. That means I’ll have to handle George on my own and trust the others to retrieve Mary and Hershel. As it stands I have minimal ability to battle against Coach George and no defense against Persephone. That only leaves me one viable option.”

“Do tell,” Mr. Transport encouraged.

A slow, half-mad smile spread across Vince’s face. The firelight’s reflection danced in his blue eyes as they seemed to drift off to some long ago place and time.

“Pure offense.”

“That seems like a poor strategy to win,” Mr. Transport told him. “Assuming you can even handle this much energy. I’ve read the reports on your activities, you know. You’ve spent all year focusing on minimizing how little you took into your body. You haven’t tried to find your limits in the slightest. For all we know this exceeds what you can contain.”

“It very well might,” Vince agreed.

“So, again I must ask, why are you so set on this course of action?”

“Because even if this has a ninety nine percent of killing me or not being enough, at least it gives us a shot. I’ll take one percent over zero any day.”

Mr. Transport let out a short laugh in spite of himself. “I think that’s more the mindset of a fool than a Hero.”

“My father once told me the best Heroes were the ones too stupid to care about the odds,” Vince replied. “So, thank you.” Vince drew in several deep breaths, saturating his lungs with oxygen. He knew once he entered the blaze he would have little time and less air to act with. A few moments lost choking on the smoke could break his concentration and cost him everything. He glanced down at his watch. Eight minutes left.

For all his brave words, the truth was Vince was scared to step forward. He wasn’t at all sure he could do this. And even if he did, he wasn’t sure he would be able to take back Hershel and Mary. He was afraid he would die in the process, of course, but that didn’t scare him nearly as much as the knowledge that there was only one chance to get them back. He, Alice, and Nick were that chance. Vince was terrified he wouldn’t be strong enough and he would let his friends down, but despite all that fear, he never questioned the fact that he had to try.

“I’m ready,” Vince said softly. Mr. Transport gave a curt nod and moved them through space. They reappeared at a central point in the fire, Mr. Transport lingering long enough only to be sure the heat didn’t render Vince unconscious. The boy stood stalwart, so Mr. Transport retreated to their previous position. Vince could survive such temperature though his ability,

but Mr. Transport had no such protection. All he could do now was wait and try to have faith in the strange little silver-haired boy.

Vince didn't breathe once he was dropped off. He'd had more than enough experience to know that in this environment the air would burn his lungs as it was already doing to his skin. Normally when he was absorbing, Vince had to reach out to connect to the energy, finding it amidst the ambient sources permeating the world around him. This time was different; from the moment he appeared, the heat was overpowering him, trying to choke and claw its way inside his fragile fleshy form. The heat wasn't just knocking at the door, it was slamming its shoulder against it and screaming profanities in an effort to force its way in. Vince didn't have to reach out this time. Instead he closed his eyes, steeled his nerves, and flung the door wide open, demanding every ounce of energy this fire could give.

For a sliver of an instant, nothing happened.

What followed next was captured on satellite imagery. The cause of it was debated for several years to come, with a wide variety of conspiracy theories centering around it and entire doctoral theses being written on the phenomenon. It wasn't until Vince's story was told and the dots were connected that the curious event finally made sense.

From the images, it initially seemed as though a glitch occurred in the system tracking the wildfire. It went from moving in standard pattern to turning inward, the direction of every path becoming a single uniform spot. The fire then began flowing in the direction of this spot. It moved at similar speeds to earlier at first, then steadily sped up in ever-increasing intervals. An image near the very end showed a circular pattern, as though the fire was swirling about like a hurricane as it was funneled down into a singularity. After that are two progressively smaller images of the fire before the final photo showing nothing.

Nothing except for miles of earth that had been scorched to the ground in mere minutes instead of the days it should have taken.

## 147.

The man's skin was like coal dipped in midnight, his muscular body scarcely contained in his black suit. The lady across the table was quite the opposite, a middle-aged woman of small stature with just a few grey hairs woven amongst her blonde ones. She, too, wore a black suit, though she had eschewed the tie in favor of a more casual appearance.

"Numbers," said the woman, her tone measured and even. "What a surprise. You must join us for tea."

"I appreciate the offer, Mrs. Tracking, but I'm afraid my time constraints are somewhat pressing," Mr. Numbers declined. He took a seat at their table, suppressing his urge to marvel at the glorious scenery their penthouse suite afforded them. Japan was always such a lovely place; Mr. Numbers intended to come back for a proper visit one day, just as he had intended for the better part of a decade.

"So I gathered. Transport did little more than a pop and drop. Quite rude," Mrs. Tracking commented.

"I'm afraid it will be much the same when he picks me up. We have a lot to talk about and little time to work in," Mr. Numbers replied. He glanced at the man, who sat so still one might believe he was little more than an exquisitely lifelike carving.

"I suppose I'll take the cue," the man said in a low, powerful baritone. He touched the hands of both Mr. Numbers and Mrs. Tracking. The world around them slowed to a crawl, then ceased to move at all from what they could discern.

"Thank you, Mr. Stop," Mr. Numbers said. "What I need to discuss with you is off the record, off the books, and will most likely label me as off the reservation."

"Oooh, sounds exciting," Mrs. Tracking said, a bubble of vivaciousness welling up in her. "I do enjoy the occasional black bag operation."

"What do you need?" Mr. Stop asked, vastly more stoic than his partner.

"Just a location," Mr. Numbers replied. "Two of our current charges have been taken and they've disabled all the methods we had to pinpoint them."

“That is hardly off the books. You’re doing your job,” Mrs. Tracking said, her voice rich in disappointment.

“No,” Mr. Numbers admitted. “I was given a direct order not to pursue.”

“I see,” Mrs. Tracking said. “That does change things.”

“I’m aware,” Mr. Numbers agreed.

“I believe I can fulfill your request, Numbers. All that’s left to determine is the price.” Mrs. Tracking flashed a grin that had signaled the end of many a man. “Let us negotiate.”

\* \* \*

Alice stepped into the common room wearing jeans and a t-shirt. She wished she had an outfit that better screamed “Warrior” but the only thing that came close was her Lander uniform. She didn’t want to face the coaches dressed like a student; something about that just felt wrong.

Vince was already waiting, his own outfit similar to hers. He glanced up at her as she entered, giving her a quick nod. If he was feeling anything like her then his stomach would be twisting in knots of worry.

“Mr. Transport went to pick up Mr. Numbers,” Vince told her. “He’ll be back in a second.”

“Okay,” Alice said, sitting down next to him.

“Nervous?” Vince asked.

“God, yes.”

“Good,” Vince said. “We’re taking on a near-impossible task. It’s going to be hard enough with just the three of us.”

“Two of us, Vince. Nick isn’t coming.”

“He’ll come,” Vince said.

“He won’t. It’s just two of us.”

“Three,” Vince corrected.

“Two.”

“Three.”

“Two.”

“Three,” Nick said, the door to the boys’ side whispering shut behind him. He was dressed in a pinstriped suit, a deep purple shirt left open at the collar. His shoes were black, well-fitted to the foot and competent for all forms of movement. His jacket was buttoned only on its top button, holding the shape together without pulling it taut to his frame.

“You’re coming?” Alice asked.

“Of course he’s coming,” Vince said, standing from the couch. “Though I’m not sure why he’s dressed like that.”

Nick shrugged. “Up until this year I’ve always dressed this way. When we do this thing I don’t want to be dressed like the ineffectual smart ass. I want to feel like the version of me that can get things done.”

“Whatever works,” Vince said, patting his friend on the back.

Nick stared at Vince for a moment. “You never waver, do you, Silver?”

“Why would I waver on the things I know?”

“Heaven save me from honest men and lunatics,” Nick replied. He looked at Alice who had risen to her feet and was staring him down.

“What changed your mind?”

“Honestly? I’m not sure,” Nick admitted. “Let’s just chalk it up to the fact that I haven’t gotten to really cut loose in a while and this seems like a good outlet.”

“You expect me to believe that?”

“Nope, which is why I didn’t bother with the truth. No sense in wasting it when you won’t trust anything I say,” Nick replied.

“She’ll trust you to help our friends,” Vince assured him.

Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers reappeared in the room, looking at the Melbrook residents.

“I have the place. Are you ready?”

The three looked at each other,

“Now or never,” Nick said.

“Then I pick now,” Alice said, forcing more courage than she felt into her voice.

“We’re ready,” Vince said. They gathered around Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers.

An instant later there was only an empty room, echoes of voices still gently reverberating off the walls.

## 148.

The night was strangely bright as Nick, Alice, and Vince stood on the dusty road. It was still used by the locals during the day, but by this time of night the only ones traveling its worn lengths were the local wildlife and the occasional tourist who got lost. There were some lights scattered about; however, if not for the moonlight, the visibility would have been greatly reduced. Nick wasn't sure if that suited their purposes well or hurt them. He suspected he wouldn't know for sure until this whole affair had concluded.

"We're sure they're coming down this route?" Alice asked, yet again.

Nick nodded. "Mr. Numbers said his coworker could tell they were moving fifty miles an hour down this highway. It's off the beaten path so if we'd launched a manhunt they wouldn't easily be spotted, but the inverse is that there aren't exits to the highway between where they were and us. They're coming this way, presumably doing the speed limit so as not to get pulled over, which means we have a couple more minutes by my calculations."

"I know, I just... what if they stop for the night? Or get a teleporter to help them? Or if wherever they're going is on this road and they've already reached it?"

"Relax," Nick ordered her. "If they had a teleporter they could use then they wouldn't be taking a truck. As for stopping, Mr. Numbers will contact us if his source senses any dramatic change in their movement. They're coming, Alice."

"Okay," Alice said, vainly willing her heart to cease its mad pounding. "Okay."

"You'll be fine," Vince assured her. "Just stick to the plan."

"Right. Get Hershel whiskey and get Mary away," Alice said.

"Bingo," Nick said. "I'll help you if I can, but my main goal is to provide Vince with cover while he fights the coaches. Hopefully, however they're holding Hershel is something Roy can easily overcome. Mary will definitely be unconscious, though."

"Why are you so sure about that?" Alice asked.

"Because if she was awake they'd be no way to stop her from trashing the vehicle. Even Persephone's nerve twitch pheromone didn't stop me from



thinking. If she can think then she can kick ass.”

“All you have to do is get her clear,” Vince reiterated. “We’ll meet up with you down the road. If for any reason we’re delayed, call Mr. Transport after five minutes for pickup.”

“But you won’t be delayed, right? You’re going to get away.”

“Of course we will,” Vince assured her. “But it never hurts to have a backup plan.”

Alice looked away from him, staring down the dark road instead. She didn’t think Vince was lying: just believing in the happiest possible scenario. Alice didn’t quite feel the optimism welling up in herself; her mind kept dwelling on all the ways this could go to shit.

“Heh.” A nervous giggle escaped Alice’s lips. “This sort of feels wrong, doing it at night. Shouldn’t we be having our showdown at high noon?”

“Personally speaking, I prefer poor lighting and shadow when facing overwhelming forces,” Nick replied.

“Don’t count on a whole lot of that,” Vince said.

Nick shot his friend a curious glance. The boy had obviously done something to prep for this fight, but he hadn’t shared it with his comrades. In fact, Vince hadn’t contributed much to any of their hurried planning process. His eyes had been sharp and focused, but not on anything the others could see. For as lunatic a situation as they were in, Vince had been calm and detached nearly the entire time. This was another variable that Nick wasn’t sure if he found comforting or terrifying.

As it would ultimately turn out, the answer was both.

\* \* \*

The man wore a grey silk shirt, black pants, and an expression of extreme derision as he paced in front of Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport.

“So I’m expected to believe that two of our top operatives were surprised and overpowered by a group of children?”

“Teens, actually, all of them old enough to be counted as adults. Except with drinking,” Mr. Transport pointed out.

The man stopped and delivered a withering glare. “This is not the time for semantics or splitting hairs. What you are telling me indicates tremendous

incompetence at best and full-out betrayal at worst. I trust I don't need to explain to you what happens if it's determined to be the latter?"

Both men would have gulped if they'd had more control over their bodies. However, Mr. Move was not notorious for his mercy or kindness, so as soon as he had heard the bad news, Mr. Move had taken over control of everything in their bodies except for speech.

"I have to tell you, I've very disappointed in you two," Mr. Move said, taking a seat on the table in front of them.

"I am certain that our supervisors will find our actions both understandable and non-traitorous. We were taken by surprise and bested. No one is perfect, after all," Mr. Numbers defended.

"Maybe they will," Mr. Move agreed. "But we'll be finding out soon. Mr. Transport is going to take us to the home office so that you two can explain things in person."

Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers would have shared a look of concern, had they been capable. They'd known this reaction was within the realm of possibility and had tried to take action to mitigate it. Unfortunately, they had yet to see the results they were hoping for, which could prove detrimental to the plan. If they went to the head office they wouldn't have their phones, and that would result in no one being on hand to retrieve their charges once the mission was complete.

"An excellent idea," Mr. Transport said. "Won't you need to give them advanced notice, though? It is a late hour, after all."

"No need," Mr. Move replied. "They were already assembled to decide how to react to the initial kidnapping. I was given full authorization to move personnel to their location should a need arise."

"Well then... excellent," Mr. Transport said, unable to think of an alternative argument. He could refuse to use his power: Mr. Move only overtook their bodies, not the abilities that they wielded. That move would end the game, though, labeling him and Mr. Numbers as traitors and moving their own safety far higher on their immediate concerns list. Still, it was a viable strategy, and one he might have to employ.

Mr. Transport was saved from his decision by a loud, authoritative knock on the door. Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport couldn't see one another from the way their heads were positioned. If they had been able to, they would have known they were both smiling quite unprofessionally.

Mitigating factors had arrived.

## 149.

The three would-be ambushers saw the distant headlights long before they heard the steady thrum of the truck's engine. The pinpoints of light were too high off the road for a sedan and too widely-spaced for a standard pickup. That left eighteen wheeler or large transport vehicle.

Nick glanced down at his watch. Estimating from the truck's speed, it would be here in another three minutes, a time which fit neatly into the expected window.

"It's them," Nick announced, shooting a quick look at his compatriots. "Everyone ready?"

Vince nodded. Alice did as well, though more hesitantly.

"Good. As soon as they stop, everybody stick to the plan," Nick instructed one last time. He'd tried to keep things general rather than bogging them down in details, but it was crucial that each one stick to their roles. Their chances of success were already disgustingly slim. If a single person broke rank then all hope would be lost.

"About that. I have a question," Alice said.

Nick glanced again at the approaching lights, now increasing in size and brightness. "Make it a quick one."

"It's about stopping the truck. How do we know standing in the road will get them to brake? What if they just mow us down?"

"Alice, did you really think I would build an entire plan that depended on basic human decency? Give me a little credit."

"Then how are you stopping the truck?"

Nick gauged the truck's speed once more. It would be here very soon, so he might as well get started.

"With a whole lot of bad luck." Nick clenched his fist and drew in a deep breath. He realized the futility of exercising fake tells when he could no longer hide his real one, but Nick Campbell was nothing if not committed to his role. Nick focused on the truck bearing down upon on them, on the front part of the cab, on the engine, and specifically on the driver. He wasn't sure who would be at the wheel, but he certainly knew who he was hoping for. He kept his mind aimed at the vehicle, and then he began to gather the bad luck.

Normally he could use a simple burst; however, for a project this big, he was going to need one doozy of a wallop.

Alice gasped and took a step back in surprise. Vince was more stoic, merely commenting, "Well, that explains the glasses."

As the luck built up in Nick, the irises of his eyes began the glow with a golden light. It was dim at first, slowly growing brighter as the power accumulated. Nick kept those radiant eyes trained on his speeding metal adversary. He needed to act when the machine was far enough away not to catch them in whatever catastrophe occurred, but close enough to be quickly reachable by Alice. Optimum timing would come down to a difference of mere seconds. The right corner of Nick's mouth tugged upward ever so slightly. He hadn't had a challenge like this in years.

The truck grew nearer and the time was at hand. Nick hardened his focus, shifted just a touch more bad luck in the driver's direction, and then let fly.

What happened next was an orchestra of malfunction. The engine caught fire and began billowing smoke, all four tires blew out simultaneously, and both axles snapped as the truck came careening to the ground. It dove forward in a headfirst motion, smashing the grill into the ground and severely crumpling the front compartment. It skidded across the cement, coming just on the verge of tipping before slamming back onto its base. Dust flew freely into the air and a sea of shrapnel lay in the truck's wake. Though it was a tremendous amount of action, it occurred in mere seconds. By the time Nick's eyes had dulled to their normal brown, the only sound remaining on the dark country road was the soft crackling of flames coming out of the engine.

"Holy shit," Alice said, her voice dumbstruck.

"Worship me later," Nick chided her. "Right now we've got to get over there before they can recover."

He and Vince began dashing down the road at top speed. Alice lifted off the ground and accelerated, quickly passing them in the race to save their friends.

\* \* \*

"Well, that was a shitwreck," Coach George commented calmly as he tossed Mary over his shoulder. The tall man had switched to his robotic form at the first wobble they'd felt from the floor. The crash had been predominantly absorbed by the front of the vehicle, but Hershel still found himself sore, pitched to the side, and with blood trickling from where his

handcuffs had pulled against his skin. It seemed Coach George had lifted Mary up during the worst of it, otherwise she would have been tossed about since she wasn't restrained to the floor.

"What was that?" Hershel asked, his head finally clearing up with the input of these new injuries.

"Hey, Persephone, report. Did you hit a squirrel or something?" Coach George demanded.

No response came from the smoking front cab.

"Fuck. Guess this just became a one-man job." Coach George kicked open the back door, sending it sprawling off its hinges. He turned back to regard Hershel. "Kid, it's been fun but my job is delivery of your friend, not to deal with whatever the hell just smashed my truck. Looks like at least you're off the hook. I can only fly with one passenger."

A series of flaps on Coach George's back opened and his legs began pulse with a green energy. Of course, of course he could fly. Hershel cursed inwardly. Someone had come to save them, and now Coach George was going to soar off before they could reach Mary. Coach George was going to get away and Hershel was going to be just sitting here. Useless as always. It was amazing Coach George had even bothered chaining him to the ground. Hershel blinked and looked at his restraints. His hands were still bound by a long length of chain, but the bolt that held him to the floor had been ripped off in the crash. Hershel sucked in a long breath that made his ribs ache. He made a snap decision.

Coach George was still powering up his legs when over two hundred pounds of husky student slammed into his back. Before he could bring himself to believe what was happening, a chain had been thrown around his neck, then wrapped over again. Hershel managed three more layers before George reached up and snared his right arm.

"It has occurred to you that in this mode I don't need oxygen, right?"

"I pretty much assumed it," Hershel wheezed. Holding himself onto George's back was already proving a difficult task to maintain. That had been the true purpose of looping his chains: it bound him to the metallic man with something more than his poor arm strength.

"So what are you doing?"

"You can't fly with two people," Hershel replied.

“Really, kid? You’ve spent your whole life living in the shadow of your better alter ego, and now you decide you want to play Hero? I’ve got an idea; let’s skip to the part where you realize you can’t cut it and just let go. Otherwise things might get... troublesome.” On his last word Coach George tightened his grip on Hershel’s arm. Hershel managed to bite back a cry. George’s fingers felt like they were already gripping him on the bone and Hershel was under no illusions that this was the strongest he could clutch.

“Roy isn’t the only son of Titan. Do your worst; I won’t let you take Mary,” Hershel spat back, his voice low as he tried to keep it from quivering.

“Have it your way,” Coach George replied.

Hershel wasn’t able to stop the next scream that rose, or any of the many that followed.

## 150.

George - he had ceased to think of himself a coach since this night's inception - was both surprised and aggravated. The tear-stained butterball now panting on the truck's cock-eyed floor had held on longer than he'd expected. It had taken no less than seven breaks in his arm to finally force Hershel to let go. Of course, George could have just ripped the damn thing off in the first place; however, he knew that wouldn't have sat well with the man at the top of the ladder.

George turned his back on the softly weeping boy and readjusted his grip on Mary. It didn't matter that he'd been slowed down. All that mattered was the girl. That was his job and that was what he would deliver. George was a singularly focused man. He took care of the mission at all costs. That was what had made him a great Hero, and, ironically, what had knocked him down to the point of teaching snot-based brats how to fight.

George stepped out into the crisp late-spring night. He flexed his rudders and checked his energy levels. Flying took some extensive warming up of his leg thrusters, but he was nearly there, even with Hershel's delay. He'd be ready to take off in less than a minute.

George made it fewer than five steps away from the battered vehicle when a pillar of flame thick as a fist came rocketing past him, missing only by a few inches. It struck the ground several feet away, the tar immediately bubbling at the sudden influx of heat. It was a bold move, one that gave away both position and tactical advantage in favor of declaring one's intentions. George knew plenty of fire users, but only one stupid enough to make an opening gambit like that. He turned around to greet his opponent.

"Reynolds," George acknowledged, his voice tinged with an electronic variable.

Vince stood down the road, illuminated by the still smoldering spot at George's back. The air around him shimmered as its temperature was forced upward. He was practically leaking energy; the guy must have absorbed a house fire or something. Gone were any traces of the usual happiness and optimism that usually peppered his expression. In their place was a vicious stare and eyes that said quite clearly that the only way one of them would come away from this was in a broken, bloody mess. It was a shame things had to go this way; George felt like he could have sculpted this kid into a real warrior.



“Let Mary go,” Vince demanded. His tone wasn’t angry or impatient. It was calm and flat as the waters of an abandoned bath tub.

“Sorry, Reynolds, not going to happen,” George replied.

“What if we say pretty please?” Nick Campbell stepped into view from the behind the front of the truck. He must have been making sure Persephone was down for the count. Smart kid. He edged slightly closer to his friend, though the emanating heat forced a healthy distance between the two. In his hands were a pair of guns, one a standard black pistol but the other a long-barreled silver six-shooter.

“Campbell, I thought you were one of the bright ones. What are you doing out here?” George just needed a little more time to charge up and he could get away without having to risk his unconscious package in a throwdown with these kids.

“Friendship can make us do some spectacularly stupid things,” Nick replied. He squeezed the trigger with his right hand and sparks flashed off George’s torso as the bullet ricocheted.

“Whoa, kid, not even a warning shot?”

“That was the warning shot,” Nick replied evenly.

George assessed the situation and weighed his options. Reynolds was pissed off enough to actually fight worth a damn and clearly hopped up on more energy than usual. Campbell was practically worthless if all he had was a pair of guns, but he could be surprisingly clever and behaved like he had ice water in his veins. Adair was floating overhead, trying to stay unnoticed as she clutched a huge rock. Whatever their plan was, it couldn’t be that sophisticated. Still, he was under strict orders to deliver the girl undamaged, and with kids this inexperienced, they could easily make a mistake and injure their friend.

“Last chance,” Vince said, taking a step forward. Flames began swirling in his hands as he prepared to release a dual barrage of fireballs. “Let Mary go.”

At long last George’s thrusters came online and showed a ‘Ready’ status.

“Thanks, but no thanks,” George replied. His robotic face wasn’t really equipped to smile, though it did put forth an impressive level of effort. He activated the thrusters and began to lift off the ground.

It was only because of his enhanced hearing that George was able to make out the gunshot over the roar of his leg engines. He did see the barrel of the six-shooter in Nick's left hand flash, and that was the last thing he saw for several seconds. A white-hot explosion of light erupted in front of his eyes, blinding his sensors and forcing him back to the ground. He heard another sound, the soft whistle of an object in free fall and put two and two together. The idiots had shot something to blind him so Adair could drop that stupid rock on him. It was a completely brainless plan and the only person it might genuinely hurt was Mary. Coach George threw up both his arms, gauging the rock's strike point on sound alone. He managed to deflect it with his forearms, shattering it into a dozen pieces that scattered along the ground.

It was only after George had lowered his arms and shaken his head in a vain attempt to get his visual sensors back to full functionality that he realized his left shoulder was considerably lighter. A quick glance to the rear confirmed his suspicions as a blonde figure holding a brunette one sped across the sky.

"You little shits," he cursed.

"Come on, did you really think we'd be stupid enough to fight you with Mary in danger?" Nick taunted. "A little misdirection is the key ingredient in any theft."

"I suppose it is," George agreed. "What was that thing you shot at me?" His vision was finally clearing up as his system compensated for the damaged lenses.

"Phosphorous bullet: a little something one of my real teachers whipped up years ago," Nick replied, his own face having no trouble displaying its cocky grin.

"Nice job there, kid, sincerely. Though I'm curious how you expected the rest of this to play out. You do realize I can easily catch that girl, right?"

"Actually, we didn't even know you could fly," Nick replied. "But it doesn't really matter."

"And why is that?" George asked.

"Because Mary isn't here to get hurt anymore," Vince answered.

The silver-haired boy took three steps forward and the inferno broke loose.

## 151.

Alice rocketed through the air as fast as she dared move with Mary's thankfully light frame clutched in her grasp. She didn't know how the small girl was still asleep, though she was smart enough to guess it had something to do with the metal headband wrapped around her skull. Alice glanced behind her to see if Coach George was somehow following her. She'd been so shocked when he lifted off the ground that the rock had slipped from her grasp. It was fortunate Nick had fired in time for the plan to work so she could steal Mary away in the confusion. Still, she had no idea how they were going to keep him busy long enough for her and Mary to get away.

Alice slowed the pace at which she was cutting through the air. She needed to get Mary awake, which meant stopping to take off the headband. It was a risk, because Coach George might catch up to her in the time it took. Alice thought it was even riskier to continue through all this without Mary's help, though. Vince had assured her they could handle Coach George. Alice slowed to a hover and she lightly descended to the ground.

She would trust in her friends.

\* \* \*

George skirted another fireball and nearly stepped into a column of focused flames. George wasn't someone who normally feared a little heat; however, the flames that Reynolds was pumping out were intense enough to make him concerned for his inner circuitry. He pulled back and raised his arm to take aim, but the burning road made getting a precise bead on his target quite difficult. It certainly didn't help that Vince's attacks didn't need to be precise to be troublesome, as the boy had clearly spent his two weeks crafting the art of the area blast. Before George could get a shot off, a blazing wall rose up in front of him, obscuring his vision entirely.

Vince soon burst through it, reabsorbing the energy around him while doling out new bursts of power. So far the dance of these two warriors had been one of distance by necessity. Vince was keeping the area around him at high enough temperatures that George would sustain damage to enter it. This kept the older combatant's exceptional strength and skill restrained while giving Vince a temporary advantage. George knew the kid never absorbed too much power, so sooner or later he would run dry and George could put a swift end to this foolishness. Vince released another flurry and George hurried to get out of the way.

From a safe distance Nick watched calmly as the world burned around him. Most people probably would have been surprised to see Vince fare so well against his former coach, given his performance all year. Nick was not one of those people. He had long ago noticed the pattern that indicated Vince was an “all on the line” kind of fighter. He was good most of the time, yet he could never tap into his true potential. That was, of course, unless his back was to the wall. Then the guy could come out of his corner swinging. And if it was his friends in danger instead of himself... well, that was when you saw what good ole Silver was really made of.

Still, he couldn't keep this pace up forever and they both knew it. Even if the fire's energy didn't run out, his own eventually would. He was using a lot of movement to try and keep George on the defensive and that would take its toll. Nick had originally planned to get to the truck and slip Hershel some whiskey; however, a series of poorly timed fireballs had cut him off from access to it. That was okay; Nick knew he would get the chance to play his roll soon enough. He just hoped it was at a point before all hope of victory was lost.

\* \* \*

“Come on, come on, wake up already,” Alice said, bobbing through the air. She'd peeled the band off of Mary and taken back to the skies; however, the telepath had remained unresponsive.

“They need you, Mary. We need you. I need you. I don't know what to do without you,” Alice pleaded to the unconscious form cradled in her arms. “I don't know if I should even be running away right now. I know I can't help, and I'd only be a distraction, but... I'm tired of only being good at running away.”

Alice moved upward in the air, hoping the chilly breeze would snap Mary into the waking world.

“You know when you fought Chad in the midterms and I ran away? I hated that, and I almost came back. Nick convinced me that sometimes being a Hero means knowing when to retreat, though. Knowing how to apply your assets so that don't they get in each other's way. Looking back at that moment now I can't believe I fell for that bullshit. Then again, I fell for a lot of his bullshit. God, Mary, please wake up already. I want to talk to you, to tell about everything that's happened, to get your opinion on what I should do. But most of all I want to save our damn friends. And I can't do that. We need you.”

Alice began flying faster, causing the wind to tear at her eyes and

whip her hair about violently.

“We need you, Mary. So please wake up.”

\* \* \*

George got off a series of shots, driving Reynolds back as he rolled away. It was bad luck that George’s projectiles were bolts of energy, but good luck that Reynolds had never experimented with his repertoire enough to see if he could absorb them. Now was not the time to try and find out, so the kid had to dodge. Finally given a bit of breathing room, George decided he had wasted enough time with this grudge match. There was no doubt he could still outfly the Adair girl, but every minute this went on meant finding her would be more difficult. Since Reynolds seemed to still have gas in the tank, George decided on an alternate method for victory.

He dashed toward the truck, able to leap past the surrounding flames that had deterred Nick, and hopped in the back. He emerged moments later, right arm holding Hershel’s battered body and left arm wrapped around his throat, choking off any protests Hershel might have been voicing. For good measure, George finally used his thrusters and rose several feet into the air.

“*Enough!*” George screamed at his top volume. “Unless you’re in the mood for barbecued hostage, I’d refrain from any more pyrotechnics.”

Vince stopped in his tracks, a half-formed fireball reabsorbing into the hand that held it.

“There’s a good student, finally doing as you’re told,” George said from his airborne perch. “I swear, kid, if you’d shown that much spirit through the year you could have been second in the class.”

Vince returned his verbal volley with only a vicious stare.

“No demands that I release your friend? Good, glad we’re past that phase. Now, here is what is going to happen. I’m going to fly off with your buddy in my possession. When I catch up with Alice, I’m going to trade him out for Mary. I’m then going to fly away and you all are never going to see me again. Clear?”

Vince only glowered at the metallic man hovering in the air.

“Don’t be such a sore loser, kid. Maybe you should have paid more attention in the dean’s boring class. I mean, didn’t it ever occur to you that I might use the one of you without powers as a human shield?”

“As a matter of fact, it did,” Nick quipped from twenty feet away on

George's right.

Nick's revolver barked its second shot and Hershel forced out a strangled scream of pain.

## 152.

George didn't really have the capacity to blink in his current form, but if he could he certainly would have done so in surprise. Blood flowed from the fresh bullet wound in Hershel's right shoulder onto the dirty grey metal of George's arm.

"Shit, Campbell, are you fucking blind? Not only did you try and shoot me with a bullet we both know wouldn't hurt, but you missed and hit your friend."

Hershel twitched violently for a few seconds before becoming still. George had just enough time to wonder if the boy had gone into shock when Hershel's head flung forward and then smashed its back into George's face. The world morphed into static as George was sent reeling through the sky and crashed to the ground, his grip and direction lost as he struggled to understand how his hostage had mustered enough strength to hurt him.

Had George been able to pay more attention he would have gotten an immediate answer to his question, for while it was Hershel Daniels that slipped from George's grasp, it was Roy Daniels who crashed into the ground. Nick and Vince dashed to his side.

"Are you okay?" Vince asked.

Nick didn't bother with a verbal query; he didn't know how long this transformation would last without supplementation. So he pulled a silver flask from his pocket and slapped it into Roy's left hand. The right arm was dangling uselessly, Hershel's significant injuries all the more apparent on Roy's muscular form.

Roy tore the top off the flask with his teeth and hurriedly gulped down the contents. He tossed it to his side and pulled himself up to a standing position. Glancing at the bullet wound in his arm, only then did he finally speak.

"You coated a bullet in whiskey?"

"Seemed like the fastest way to get it into your bloodstream," Nick replied.

Roy gave him a curt nod, then looked at the metallic figure that was moving towards them once more. "I rang his bell pretty good, but we need to hurry if we want to keep him from flying off."

Vince gestured to Roy's arm. "What happened? Are you sure you can fight with that?"

A dark look passed over Roy's face. "I'm dead fucking sure. If Hershel can be man enough to hold onto to that psycho's neck while he snaps his bones then there's no way I'm backing down."

"The girls should be far enough away now, it might be prudent to retreat and heal," Nick pointed out.

"To hell with that. Do you know what Hershel's last thought was before I took over?" Roy asked, his eyes unwavering from his formerly airborne opponent.

"Do tell," Nick sighed, already seeing where this was going.

"His last thought after being kidnapped, beaten, and taken hostage by someone he trusted was 'Sorry about the arm'." The knuckles on Roy's left hand cracked with a thunder that left lightning envious. "No way I'm letting my little brother show me up like that. I owe that tin man son-of-a-bitch. I owe him hard."

"I'll fight with you," Vince said, stepping next to him. Roy stayed focused on the steadily approaching target, but Vince spared a glance over at Nick.

"In for a dime, in for a dollar," Nick replied, taking a few steps back but raising his weapons. He was under no impression that he'd be able to make any more difference in wounding George, but perhaps a well-timed shot could prove a distraction. At this point it was all he had left.

"Just for reference, how resistant to fire are you?" Vince asked Roy with the little time that remained.

"No idea," Roy replied. "But I bet we're about to find out."

\* \* \*

The knock on the Melbrook door was quickly followed by its forceful opening. Seconds later Dean Blaine, along with a petite elderly woman and a medium-sized man with jet-black hair, entered the living room.

"You two had better have a damned good explanation," Dean Blaine ranted. "First your students get outed by one of their classmates, then you contact me that two of them are missing and point me toward another student, this one who assures me the perpetrators were two of my staff. An accusation that would have been laughable if not for the fact that I am now unable to find



either one of them. Now I come in here and find you both just sitting there, seemingly without a care in the world. So you'd both better tell me what is going on and where my students are and I mean now!"

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport both sat still as early morning in response. Mr. Move, however, stepped forward to meet the dean.

"Dean Blaine, I can assure you that everything is well under control and you have nothing to worry about."

Dean Blaine strode directly by Mr. Move and leaned in to yell more at the sitting men. "Are you two deaf? I said I want to know what's going on."

"Perhaps you would feel more at ease if you sat down and relaxed," Mr. Move commanded. He was going to take hell for using his power on the dean, but it seemed unavoidable at the moment. However, things did not go as Mr. Move expected. Rather than hunkering down with the other two, Dean Blaine spun around and drove his fist into Mr. Move's temple with a single fluid motion. Mr. Move tumbled to the floor, not accustomed to taking blows and certainly not from someone as experienced as Dean Blaine.

"I wasn't talking to you, whoever you are," Dean Blaine said to the now unconscious man. "I was talking to these two."

'These two' were experiencing a tingle across their skin as they regained authority over their appendages. They exchanged a quick glance to confer that they were on the same page about coming clean with the dean and found that they, in fact, adamantly were. Before they could rise to a standing position, however, Dean Blaine leaned in and placed a hand on each of their shoulders.

"Last chance, gentlemen. Where. Are. My. Students?"

## 153.

Roy threw a vicious haymaker that George sidestepped with ease. George capitalized on Roy's open side by delivering two quick jabs to the boy's ribs and then kneeing him in the diaphragm. Roy coughed as the wind left his body and he sank to a knee. George moved in to put him down for good when a horizontal pillar of fire smashed into his head, momentarily blinding him and sending his temperature to dangerous levels. George was forced to roll away and regroup, a consequence of which was that Roy was afforded the same privilege.

George had to admit it: Daniels had gotten a lot better since the start of the year. He was thinking his movements through, recovering well from hits, and fighting with a brain instead of all brawn. All those weeks slugging it out with the number one rank had done him a world of good. Not so much that he could pose an actual challenge to George, though. This fight would have been over in minutes if not for Reynolds doling out those flame-based blasts. Every time George went to return fire, Roy came at him in close range. The two were focusing on their specialties and keeping him off balance enough so that he couldn't permanently remove either one from the fray. It was a terrible strategy if they wanted to win, but for buying time, he had to concede it was pretty functional. Somewhere deep down inside his metallic system George felt a sensation akin to pride. The little dipshits had actually learned.

George activated his thrusters and began rising into the air. Unlike his opponents, he had no compelling reason to try and win this fight. All he had to do was get away and recapture the Smith girl for delivery. Unfortunately, Roy had already recovered and was ready for this. He leapt several feet in the air, grabbing George by the leg and getting a face full of thruster fire for his trouble. Roy didn't even seem to notice; he pulled himself out its range and tightened his grip.

"I'd think between you and your brother one of you boys would think of a different strategy than just clinging on to me," George said.

"If it ain't broke don't fix it," Roy snapped back. He tested his right arm and found it still unresponsive. He knew it would heal eventually, probably within the half hour. That just wasn't much help at the moment, though. It was a shame, if he'd had both appendages he could have been hammering away on George while in this position; instead he was leaving himself wide open. Roy steeled himself for whatever was about to come. If Hershel could take it so could he.

For his part, George wasn't feeling particularly creative. He raised his own arm and fired off several bolts of energy into Roy's torso. The boy's grip was shaken as the pain rippled through him, but he held on. George readied himself for another volley; however, he was forced to sweep through the air instead to dodge a flurry of fire from Vince on the ground.

"You little pains in the ass," George swore. "How long do you think you can keep this up? Two more minutes? Maybe five? It doesn't matter! I'll catch that girl before the sun is up no matter what you do. I'm a trained, experienced, veteran Hero, and you are just three Powereds who got a little control. The three of you alone could never beat me."

George's arms suddenly shot out to his sides and his legs snapped together, locking his whole form into a rigid lower case "t" shape. Though his face was capable of only showing the barest emotion, Roy still recognized the look that swept through his eyes. It was the same one he'd worn on a fall night only a few weeks into the school year. Roy turned his face to George and gave him the biggest smile he could muster.

"Guess it's a good thing they made five of us, then." Roy released his grip and fell away as George was sent violently slamming into the ground. The concrete exploded upward at the force of his impact and cracks sprawled outward all the way to the road's edge. Before the dust could settle, George was airborne again, being lifted up and driven back into the roughly the same spot with ever increasing force.

It was on his third trip up that George finally saw her, the five-foot-tall Valkyrie being lowered to the ground by her blonde escort. Their eyes locked for a moment before he slammed into the earth once more. The next time up he used his thrusters to try and break free, but all that earned him was a faster return to the earth. George was impressed; he'd fought telekinetic Supers before and knew holding onto someone as strong as he was took a whole lot of power.

The others were impressed as well, though that emotion was being steadily passed by fear for the prime position. In all the time they'd known Mary she had always been calm and composed. A bit eccentric at times, certainly; however, her cheerful demeanor had faithfully shone through whatever other fleeting emotions were clouding the surface. That wasn't the Mary that strode across the concrete, though, moving steadily closer to man who had taken her. This Mary wasn't cheerful, or kind, or motherly in the slightest.

This Mary was pissed off.

At long last she reached the crater that bore a plethora of George shaped dents in it. She stood over the edge and glared down, increasing the pressure on him so moving even a finger would require tremendous effort.

“You kidnapped me,” she accused.

“Only attempted to kidnap at this point,” George pointed out. He was feeling all those drops - not even he was immune to that kind of assault - but he’d been through worse attacks and survived. He’d get free eventually; Mary couldn’t keep up this level of power indefinitely. Even if she held him down and the others beat him up, George was confident nothing they had could truly put him down for the count.

“You hurt my friends,” Mary continued.

“Now that one I’ll give you. But in fairness, they started it.”

“Do you feel even the slightest remorse for what you’ve done today?”

“Of course,” George replied. “I regret that your friend interrupted me, otherwise I could have been done with this whole mess by now.”

“I supposed asking why you did it is a waste of time,” Mary surmised.

“Why don’t you try reading my mind and see?”

Mary shook her head. “I can’t read you when you’re in that form. Maybe that’s how you hid this from me until it happened. I don’t know and I don’t care. If you’re not going to talk, then I won’t bother asking.”

“So is this the part where you try to kill me?”

“No, this is the part where I make you what you made me: helpless. Vince, drain him.”

“What?” Vince asked.

“What?” George near-yelped.

“He’s not just metallic like Stella; he’s a functional robotic life form. He was quite clear about that during our class. So that means he’s running on some kind of energy. Let’s see what happens when that tap runs dry.”

“But what if it kills him?” Vince asked.

“Then stop before he dies,” Mary instructed.

Vince thought about questioning her more, then he saw the look in her amber eyes. Not just the rage, but also the fear. She’d been taken from a place

she thought was secure by someone she thought she could trust. Now she was just trying to hold it together until it was safe to break down. Vince looked at the face of the man who had done that to her, and he could swear there was a smirk on his robotic face. Vince set his resolve.

He hopped down into the crater and pressed his hand against George's chest. He was surprised to feel electricity flow up his arm; Vince had half expected some super New Age form of power. Instead it was a good old familiar current, familiar only thanks to the man he was currently depleting. Vince wasn't sure if that was ironic or not; he'd never been good at figuring out what fit that definition. He knew it made him smile, though.

"Wait, stop," George said, the first feel hint of worry entering his voice. "You don't understand what you're doing."

"I'm stopping you," Vince replied. "I think I've got a good handle on it."

"I'm saying there's more to this than you think. You don't understand the implications."

Vince increased the rate he was pulling the energy. George had quite a bit, but sooner or later every well ran dry. He knew he was making progress because George's voice was growing weaker.

"You stupid kids... you have... no... idea..."

There was a ripple across his body and suddenly the students were staring at their former teacher's human visage. George looked tired but awake as he stared up at the five faces peering down upon him. He'd been too cocky, too sure they couldn't hurt him. Now he'd have to wait, recover, and then ambush them when they weren't expecting it. George was still plotting his next move when a pair of well-manicured hands lifted his head from the rubble and slipped a silver band around it. After that it was some time before he was allowed another conscious thought.

Alice clapped the dirt off her hands and floated back up to the road level. "That should take care of him. Now, who is calling Mr. Transport?"

"If no one objects," Nick said, plucking his phone from his pocket. "I believe Alice and I are the only ones with non-smashed or melted phones, and since she made it last time, I believe it is my turn."

The others signaled their agreement, and Nick punched in the number.

"We're ready to be picked up," he said. For the first time that year an

emotion Nick didn't intend crept into his next words, happiness bounding free and plain for anyone with sense to discern.

“All of us.”

\* \* \*

Dean Blaine handed Mr. Transport back his phone. The tall man took it and looked at the dean with uncertain eyes.

“It was Mr. Campbell. It seems they're all safe and are requesting to be picked up,” Dean Blaine informed him. “This adds only more to the heap of explanations you gentlemen owe me.”

Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers both nodded. The last few minutes had been... unpleasant. Dean Blaine had been significantly displeased with their story so far, and it was only going to get worse as they continued. They'd been fortunate he had consented to picking up Mr. Transport's phone on the possibility it could be the students in question.

“A heap of explanations, by the way, that you will be providing to me. Tonight. But after you've retrieved your charges,” Dean Blaine said. He certainly wasn't going to make the children wait any longer than they had to. They'd surely had a hard enough night, it was time for things to get easier for them. As for their caretakers, on the other hand, their evening was only just beginning.

## 154.

Morning found the Melbrook quintet clustered in their living room, a firm lockdown being adamantly enforced. The television was on, but none of those sitting in the room were paying attention. Every now and then Hershel would touch his shoulder, expecting pain to stab through his arm. A healer had been called during the night, so the physical damage had been completely negated. The other kinds were still unwelcomely present. Mary reached over and took his hand in hers, squeezing it to both give and receive some comfort.

“How do you think they’ll take it?” Vince asked, breaking the silence that had descended on them since being left alone. After a quick night’s sleep, Dean Blaine had met them at dawn to ask a few questions and outline what was going to happen next for them.

“Badly,” Nick replied. “He’s going to confirm the truth about us, and then tell them we’re not having to take the final with them. That’s not going to help the situation.”

“That’s not our fault, though,” Alice said. “We didn’t ask for our friends to get kidnapped.”

“No, but we did choose to go after them,” Nick pointed out. “I’m not trying to say we should be taking it. We’re all beat to hell in every way but the literal one. I’m just saying they won’t take that news well coupled with they what they learned last night.”

“I wonder who dropped that bomb,” Mary said quietly. “I was already out by then, so I didn’t get to hear.”

“It was some person from the DJ booth,” Alice said.

“It was Michael,” Vince corrected. The others turned to look at him. He merely shrugged. “I know what his crazy screaming voice sounds like. I heard it when he attacked me on Halloween.”

“He attacked you on Halloween?” Hershel asked.

“Why didn’t you tell me you knew who it was?” Nick tossed out as well.

“Yes, and it didn’t seem important at the time,” Vince answered in order.

“Not important? How is that not important?” Nick demanded.

“The secret was already out; what mattered at the time was getting us together and safe. Then when the whole... thing happened, it sort of slipped my mind,” Vince explained.

“Michael, huh? I wonder how he found out. Or why he bothered to out us like that,” Alice speculated.

“He had something against me; even though he won our first match he felt like I made him look bad. That’s the only motivation I ever knew about,” Vince replied.

“We’ll make sure to give him a special thank you some time,” Nick said. “On the subject, though, why didn’t any of us know about the Halloween attack?”

Vince shrugged again. “I got out of it fine. I guess I just didn’t want to worry anyone.”

“Given the events of the past twenty-four hours, I fear we’re going to need to adopt a policy of more information and worry rather than less,” Hershel noted.

“Agreed. On the plus side, we’re all okay. And we all get to come back next year,” Alice pointed out.

“I’d feel a lot safer if we knew what all it was about, though,” Mary said. “Or where Persephone snuck off to.”

The collection process of the students and the former Coach George had turned up a passenger cab coated in blood but absent the blonde kidnapper. Given all the distractions of dealing with George, there was no way to estimate when she’d made her escape, though all five said a silent prayer of thanks she’d chosen flight rather than fight. They’d barely coped with just one coach to subdue. Two would have annihilated them.

“She’ll turn up eventually,” Nick assured her. “Even the wildest rat has to come out for food.”

“I’ll feel better when she does,” Mary said. “My telepathy will give me a heads up if she’s approaching me now that I’m on guard, but I still don’t know how safe I’ll feel in my woods all summer.”

“Good thing you’re not going off to the woods alone, then,” Alice told her. “You’re spending the summer with me.”

“Am I?”



“Mary, you were the target of this whole debacle. The last one of us to be off on their own should be you,” Vince said.

“I don’t think endangering Alice is the right way to address that problem,” Mary replied.

“Endangering me? Mary, did you forget the whole my dad is worth more than some countries thing? We don’t have a security guard in my home, we have security battalions. Several of them. My father might be an ass but he takes safety seriously. If Persephone wants to take you from my home, she’d better bring an entire army of Supers or it will be an insult,” Alice said firmly.

“I’ll... um... I’ll have to check with my parents,” Mary said lamely as she struggled to find another excuse.

“Be persuasive,” Nick instructed her. “I don’t particularly feel like repeating tonight’s performance anytime soon.”

“All of you are welcome, too,” Alice added. “I have a whole wing of the house to myself, so you won’t be imposing.”

“It’s a generous offer,” Hershel said. “But I think I’ll be okay at home. I’m looking forward to getting back to Chicago for a little while.”

“Any of us could be targets, though. You should take her offer seriously,” Vince said.

“I am. And trust me when I say I’m perfectly safe at home. My dad wasn’t a billionaire, but he was a renowned Hero. Lots of his old partners and friends live on the same street as us and keep an eye out for his family. The neighborhood might look like Sunday picnics and barbeques, but it’s got more spandex and laser vision than anyone would suspect.”

“I suppose that’s a pretty safe place then,” Vince conceded.

“Agreed,” Nick said. “And while I appreciate the offer, I’ll be declining as well. This year produced an ending I really wasn’t expecting. I need to go home and figure out what that means for me as well as my future at Lander.”

“You are coming back, though,” Vince said.

“It’s sad that I know you well enough to assume that wasn’t a question,” Nick sighed. “I’ll probably be back, if for no other reason than this little nuthouse has proven to be excellent training for expecting the unexpected. I’ll also add that my place is quite safe in its own regard. Can we take me at my word on that one?”

“We can,” Vince said before anyone else could raise the fact of just how questionable Nick’s word was these days. “I’m going to say no as well. I don’t have a fortress to return to, but no one will be able to catch what they can’t find.”

“You’re going back on the road?” Alice asked.

“I am. It’s where I feel at home. Well, that and here.”

“Touching,” Nick said. “I guess that handles our plan to survive the summer. That just leaves how we’ll get through next year now that everyone knows what we really are. Anybody got a bright suggestion for that one?”

The room was silent, save for the perplexed weather man on the television reporting the strange phenomenon to strike the California wildfires.

## 155.

The reactions from most of the student body had been shocked and dismayed, but it was the freshman class filing down the hall to their exams where anger budded most prominently.

“This is utter horse shit,” Allen Wells complained, his hands itching to dole out some explosions to demonstrate his outrage. “First we find out they’re fucking Powered, then they don’t even have to take the test. I wonder who I have to blow to get on the special treatment train?”

“Were,” said Thomas’ flat voice.

“Were what?” Allen asked.

“They were Powered. Now they’re Supers,” Thomas corrected. “Did you not pay attention at all to the dean’s announcement?”

“Oh, I heard him loud and clear. We’re all stuck with the standard test to fight for spots while they’ve been just waved on through,” Allen snapped back.

“They weren’t waved through,” Will said, joining the discussion. “Two of them were kidnapped, and then the five of them subdued Coach George. Do you think your test will be harder than that?”

“What the fuck ever, there’s no way the coaches would actually do something like that. I’m sure they just objected to the Powered being let into the program at all so now they’re being tossed under the bus, just like Michael,” Allen said.

“I’m with him on this one,” Terrance stepped forward to add. “It is sort of crap that they’ve put Michael under ‘judicial review’ just for telling everyone the truth.”

“He ‘told the truth’ by breaking into a sound booth and endangering those five,” Thomas shot back. “I’m amazed they didn’t flat out drop him from the program all together.”

“They didn’t do it because they knew we would have rioted if they’d taken it that far,” Allen said, his voice raising a few octaves. The steady march toward the exam room had slowed as the discussion grew; now it was grinding to a halt. One partly pink-haired individual never broke stride, though, moving up to the debate from her position in the rear.

“Sasha,” Thomas called out. “Would you please help me explain to this imbecile that our friends are not the amoral monsters that current opinion seems to paint them as?”

Sasha never looked at him, never slowed down, never even moved her eyes. Her only response was a single pair of words delivered with such venom that clarification wasn’t needed in the slightest.

“Fuck them.”

“See, even one of their girlfriends knows they don’t belong here,” Allen declared triumphantly.

Thomas considered pushing the issue further; however, Sasha’s comment had taken most of the wind from his sails and he wasn’t sure how to recover the lost ground. Instead he retook his place in line and shook his head.

It was a good thing all five of the Melbrook students had been outed simultaneously, because Thomas had a firm suspicion they were going to be leaning on each other a lot come next year.

\* \* \*

Dean Blaine poured himself two fingers of scotch, then stepped back. After a moment’s consideration he filled up the rest of the glass. He stared at it for a few more seconds then went to his cabinet. He emerged holding a much bigger glass, dumped the original glass’s contents into it, and then filled it up the rest of the way.

The announcement had gone over about as well as he’d expected. It wasn’t the initial reaction one had to watch out for in situations like this. No one ever really grasped the full implication of big announcements immediately. No, the part he had to be on guard for was in the weeks to come, when the simmering thoughts would lead people down all the rabbit holes of possibility that he’d pursued himself nearly a year ago. They’d find the same conclusions, too. That this procedure, if evaluated and approved as successful, would significantly alter the landscape of Supers and Powereds permanently. And while it was a good thing, overall, it also meant taking the group that had been seen as secondary and elevating them to the status of equals. Dean Blaine might have slept through his college history courses, but even he knew you didn’t have to dig hard to find all the examples of that being a tumultuous process at best. At worst... well, he was going to have to keep an eye on those five next year. He was certain there were plenty of people who would like to see their little experiment declared to be a failure.

It was a shame, too; they were good kids. Under different

circumstances a few of them might have even gone all the way, with the right guidance. Dean Blaine took a big gulp of his scotch at that thought. George and Persephone... they'd been teaching here for over ten years, longer than he'd even been at Lander. For them to have stolen away with students in the middle of the night... Dean Blaine didn't think he would have truly believed it if he hadn't been present to retrieve George's unconscious body. When he was thoroughly secured, Dean Blaine intended to have a very long, very in-depth chat about exactly what the point of their little stunt had been.

For right now, though, their absence created a more pressing dilemma. Dean Blaine had only two and a half months to find adequate replacements for their roles. That included background checks, board approval, negotiations and training, a process that usually took at least a year to complete. Dean Blaine let out a sigh and drummed his fingers on the desk.

He was going to need more scotch.

## 156.

Nick slammed down the hatch on his car and looked up into the bright sky. It figured: the first time all year he genuinely needed sunglasses and they were lying in a broken heap at the bottom of the trash can. He'd have to pick up a pair of cheapos at the first gas station he passed. The drive from Lander to Vegas wasn't a particularly long one, but it was sunny as a son-of-a-bitch.

Alice was nearly done loading her own car as well, Mary's bags packed alongside hers as they struggled to fit Alice's ever-expanding wardrobe into the limited space a trunk had to offer. Mary was thankful she'd managed to talk Alice out of bringing everything home. They were coming back in a few months, after all. Mary took a step back and popped her back after the labor of packing the bags down. A part of her was sad that she wouldn't be going home for the summer, back to the peace and quiet of her woods. She was a pragmatic girl, though; she understood what her friends had risked by coming after her. To not take her safety seriously after such a gesture would be an insult to all of them, even if they didn't take it that way.

Hershel was tossing his final parcel into the car while his mother spoke in hushed tones with Dean Blaine.

"Again, I'm sorry you had to drive all the way out to pick up Hershel," Dean Blaine apologized. "We're just short-staffed of teleporters at the moment."

"It's fine," Mrs. Daniels assured him. "What about their caretakers? After what you've told me I'd like to have a little discussion with both of them, especially Mr. Transport."

"I'm not clear on much about them at the moment," Dean Blaine replied. "They're currently being debriefed by the company they work for. I haven't received any definitive word on if they'll be replaced next year or not."

"Please keep me in the loop," Mrs. Daniels said as Hershel walked up to the two.

"All done," Hershel said, patting the station wagon proudly.

"Such a strong young man," Mrs. Daniels said. "Why don't you go say goodbye to your girlfriend? We'll be leaving as soon as I take care of something."

Hershel took the hint and set off to give Mary an emphatic but

publicly-appropriate farewell.

“Was there something else?” Dean Blaine asked uncertainly.

“Yes, but not from you,” Mrs. Daniels replied. “You’ve been wonderfully helpful. Thank you for coming out explain things in person.”

“Ma’am, it is quite literally the very least I can do,” Dean Blaine said.

Mrs. Daniels walked across the parking lot, eventually stepping off the concrete and onto the grassy area that surrounded it. Sitting beneath a tree making some adjustments to the straps on his backpack was a silver-haired boy, thoroughly absorbed in the task at hand.

“You’re Vince, if I remember correctly.”

Vince looked up and gave his friend’s mother a polite smile. “Yes, ma’am.”

“I wanted to let you know how much I appreciate you going after my son. All three of you. It must have been terrifying, and I’m so very amazed you all had the courage to do something like that.”

“It’s not a big deal. Hershel would have the same for any one of us. We’re friends.”

“You’re good friends to have. Still, handling someone as strong as George, you must be one amazing Super.”

“Only eighth in my class,” Vince told her.

“I’m sure that will change soon,” she assured him. “I have a question for you, though. As strong as you are, do you think you could beat me in a fight?”

“I beg your pardon?”

“I’m asking you if you think you have it you to physically render me unconscious, should we engage in an altercation.”

Vince squirmed slightly, searching her face for a snicker or smile to show that she was joking. He found nothing.

“I suppose I probably could,” Vince answered at last. “But I’d really much rather never find out.”

“That is a shame, because the only way I’m letting the young man who helped save my son wander off on his own with no food or shelter is

when I have been knocked stone cold out,” Mrs. Daniels informed him.

“I’m a little confused, ma’am.”

“You will be coming home with Hershel and me, where you will be subjected to proper meals and a roof over your head all summer long,” Mrs. Daniels explained. “Along with adequate safety should anyone else make an attempt on one of you.”

“Thank you very much, but I couldn’t impose,” Vince said.

“I feel I was quite clear about this already, young man. Either go put your bag in the car or put up your fists, because there are only two possible endings to this discussion.”

“I... yes, ma’am,” Vince said, looking deep into her eyes and realizing this woman was one hundred percent not fucking around. He headed over to the station wagon where Hershel was already waiting.

“She strong-armed you into coming home with us, didn’t she?”

“How’d you know?”

“I know my mom,” Hershel replied with a shrug. “If it makes you feel better, you never stood a chance.”

“Not particularly,” Vince said. “But I suppose there are worse things than spending a summer with a friend.”

“It’s not excitement, but I’ll take it,” Hershel said. He slapped Vince heartily on the back. “Try and enjoy yourself, man. Next year is going to be one hell of an uphill battle. Speaking of, there’s this group I hang out with back in Chicago, sort of a simulated attack strategy group. I think you’ll fit in really well with them.”

“Is this that LARPing thing you told me about?”

“Exactly. Now, let me ask, what mythical creature do you see yourself as? Because while your hair and cheekbones lend themselves to elf, I personally think you’ve got the fighting spirit of an orc.”

Vince tossed his bag in the bag of the car and then buckled himself in. It seemed that summer would, at the very least, not be boring.



## Epilogue

For what it was, the warehouse was actually quite well-maintained. One often expected places such as this to be leaky and derelict; however, this particular enclosure was about as homey as it could be with concrete floors and walls. The lack of windows and the single entrance certainly didn't add to the domestic appeal, though the sprawled out rugs and series of sofas did bring several degrees of comfort to the equation. It only went to show, good or evil, human or Super, at the end of the day, everyone needed a soft place to sit.

Persephone limped through the entrance and approached the center area where the others sat. She'd been in too much of a hurry to look for a healer, only pausing to make a quick call from a payphone so they knew the operation had failed. It had been a hellish several hours getting here, and she'd only made this good of time thanks to a car stolen outside a dusty gas station.

Persephone made it halfway across the room when she felt her body lift from the ground and be pulled to a red chair. She was set down gently in the soft leather surface, facing three of her cohorts.

The oldest was the one who had relocated her, a powerful figure wearing a tattered and patched red coat that hung to his knees. To his right was a pale blonde woman as beautiful as she was silent, which is to say very. On his left was a young boy, barely over the age of ten, who looked at her with a gaze so furtively curious she couldn't stand to be around him for more than a few minutes at a time.

"So the mission failed, and what's more, George was taken," the man said, his voice dark, deep, and calm as a mile below the ocean's surface.

Persephone nodded. She didn't need to bother with excuses. He was a seasoned warrior. He understood that sometimes things didn't go as planned.

"That is unfortunate," the man said, drawing out the word as if he was considering the appropriateness of its use. "Of all possibilities, it didn't occur to me that our efforts would result in losing George."

"Me either," Persephone admitted.

"Still, you two drew enough attention for our other agent to complete his job, so on the whole we'll have to consider this as a success," the man added on. "And I'm glad you were able to make it back to us, Persephone."

There is still so much work to do. Even more now that we've lost George."

Persephone glanced at her feet, ashamed she hadn't been able to help save George. The mission directives were clear, though: if they were compromised, she was to make escape the first priority. George could hide out in his robot form where he had no fear of telepaths. She would only have her discipline to rely on, discipline that could be broken by a professional with enough time. As her eyes stared at her worn and dirty shoes, she noticed something. The wound on her leg had closed, and the aches she'd been carrying since the wreck were no longer present. She turned her eyes upward and was greeted by a comforting smile from the man she'd once so greatly feared.

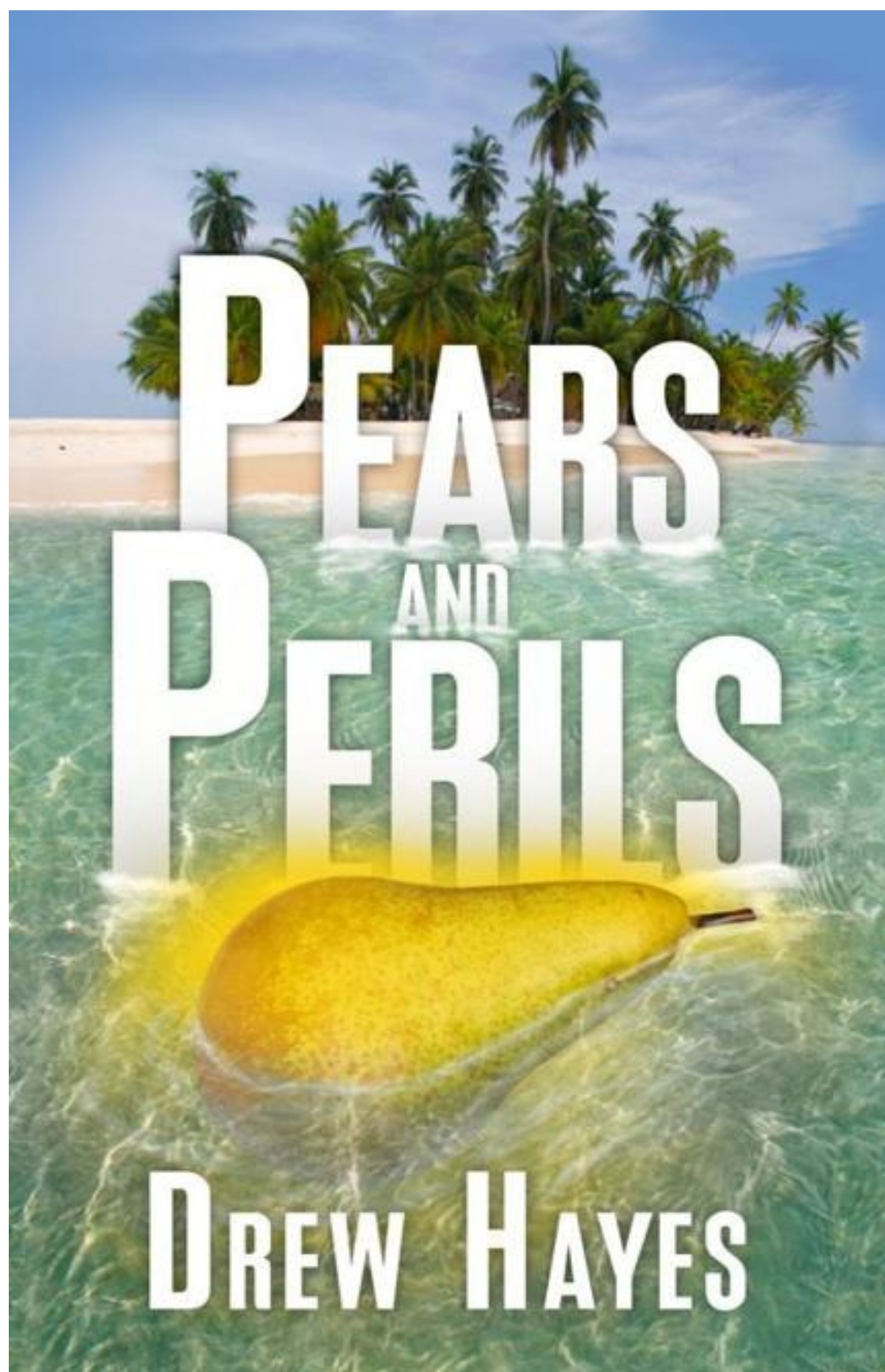
"You don't need to worry, Persephone, I'm not mad at you. You did as you were instructed along every step of the way. And yes, while this operation certainly hit a snag, I find myself hard pressed to be too upset about it. After all, if he was able to help take down one as strong as George, then I can only conclude my son has flourished quite well in my absence. I'm a bit too topped off with pride to feel anything negative at the moment. So rest well; you've earned it."

The man reached over and patted her on the knee. "I mean it. Enjoy this down time, because when next we move it will be a long while before we stop again."

Persephone understood. She had an area that was hers to stay in within the warehouse, but she didn't want to leave the comfort of his presence. Instead she lay down on the couch she was already sat upon and placed her head against the cushy arm in place of a pillow.

The future held terrible battles and nightmarish tasks, there was no question of that. For today, though, for just this moment, there was time to rest.

**And now, a free sample chapter from another Drew  
Hayes novel:**



# 1.

“Tucker! My office! Now!” Mr. Henderson didn’t even bother to make his already thunderous voice seem civil. Everyone within the distance of his shout, which is to say everyone within a forty cubicle range, could guess that whatever Clint Tucker was being called in for, it likely ended with a boot up his ass: likely a boot with a pink slip attached.

Mr. Henderson stood in the door of his office, his impressive bulk nearly blotting out the silver-haired gentleman behind him. Dr. Caruthers (he didn’t get a Ph.D. in economics to be called Mr. Caruthers thank-you-very-much) stood silently in the shadow of the larger man, content to represent himself physically rather than vocally. His physical representation was quite excellent at that: a tall, lean figure in a suit that cost more than the car any given person on this floor drove. His face was placid and if one didn’t know better, one would have thought him to have a look of kindness. Those who were more informed thought of it as the expression an alligator wears as it drifts through the swamp. It was an expression that conveyed a willingness to wait, but only until there was prey within striking distance.

“Tucker!” Mr. Henderson’s voice roared through the office once more.

Slowly, as if he were savoring every moment he still had in the fluorescent environment, Clint Tucker rose from his cube and began plodding toward the office. He was slightly taller than most of the employees, with a shock of light brown hair and muddy chocolate eyes. The suit he wore was off the rack, the kind of garment Dr. Caruthers would buy for his butler, only to give himself something to chuckle about. Clint was a curious fellow; he always ambled where others rushed and never seemed to sweat the frequent rumors of layoffs swirling about the office.

“You wanted me, Boss?” Clint asked evenly as he stared at the purple vein bulging in the front of Mr. Henderson’s bald head. It swelled and pulsed whenever Mr. Henderson was angry. Once upon a time he’d covered it up with hats and toupees, but over the years Mr. Henderson had come to embrace his vein for the motivational tool it was.

“We need to have a little chat.” Mr. Henderson pronounced ‘chat’ the way mean-spirited judges pronounced maximum sentences.

“Cool.” Clint slid past the larger man and took the nearest unoccupied seat in the contemporary office. There was a large oak desk, motivational posters decorating the walls, and it was filled with natural light from a window with a gorgeous view of the city. Mr. Henderson had fought, backstabbed, and kissed all manner of ass to procure this office. Publicly he’d say his children were his pride and joy. After a few scotches, though, he could be pressed to admit it was this office.

Mr. Henderson shut the door firmly and took his time working around

the desk to his high-backed leather chair. He sat with a considerable thump and looked at the young man across from him. Silence hung in the air as the two older men stared down the youthful face in front of them. Clint was barely twenty-four, hardly more than a baby as far as these two business veterans were concerned. He had his whole life ahead of him, or would have if circumstances were different.

“Clint,” Mr. Henderson began softly, switching up his vocal tactics to keep the boy on his toes. “We’re here to talk about Project Jefferson.”

Clint nodded solemnly. He’d been under no illusions that this could be about anything different.

“As you know, the program was supposed to create a centralized system into which people could feed all of their e-mail addresses and then access them from a single point. Now, when you gave us the go ahead to begin beta-testing, we discovered an unfortunate side effect of the system. Would you care to venture what that is?”

“It deletes all of their e-mail?”

“It deletes all of their e-mail!” Mr. Henderson shouted, slamming his fist of the desk before realizing that Clint had actually replied. “Wait... you knew?”

“It seemed like it was a possibility when I looked at the code. But the people at the top wanted us to hit their deadline so I rolled the dice.” Clint nodded unapologetically toward Dr. Caruthers. The doctor was head of the Engineering and Development department despite his utter lack of knowledge in anything technical beyond checking stocks on his phone. “When people who are clueless are made into leaders, there are bound to be mistakes.”

Dr. Caruthers felt his eyebrows go up in surprise. Who in the hell did this whelp think he was?

“Now see here, young man, I happen to have a doctorate in economics from a very prestigious university-”

“Tell me the difference between Python and Perl. Tell me how long it takes an average programmer to write one hundred lines of code. Tell me what a reasonable deadline for developing software like this is. I know you can’t do the last one, you already fucked that up, didn’t you?” There was no anger in Clint’s voice, no fire being verbally released. He talked calmly, as though he were stating obvious facts like, “The sun is hot” or “Coffee wakes you up.”

Dr. Caruthers’ mouth opened and closed several times, his mind trying to wrap itself around the insolence that had just been thrust at him. He was accustomed to being on the offense; the idea of one of his grunts speaking to him in such a way confounded his strategies so much that he found himself trapped in a moment of inaction.

Fortunately, Mr. Henderson suffered no such dilemma.

“I will hear no more of this!” Mr. Henderson roared, rising from his desk like the licking fires of hell. “Dr. Caruthers is an outstanding leader who has always valued the opinions of his employees. If you had problems with the deadline, it’s your own fault for not coming to me or him with them. The one who made the mistake was you, and we’re throwing you on your ass for it. I want you out of my goddamned office in the next five minutes or I’ll break out the pepper spray we keep for dealing with protestors!”

“Whatever you say,” Clint replied with a shrug. He headed out of the office and paused at his desk only long enough to pick up a pen he’d brought from home. Clint didn’t keep any personal items at his desk; it would be a silly practice given his line of work. There were a few consolatory nods from co-workers: had he been around longer they would have stopped him and found a place to meet up to throw a good-bye party. He hadn’t been around that long, though. He never was.

Back in the office, Dr. Caruthers at last found his voice. “I cannot believe such an important project was handed over to that impudent little bastard.”

Mr. Henderson nodded his agreement. “It was a real disappointment, especially given how outstanding his references were. When he first showed up his letters of recommendation were so glowing I thought they were fake. That’s why I kicked the decision up to you.”

Dr. Caruthers felt a scathing jab wither on his tongue. He’d nearly forgotten that he’d been the one to approve Clint Tucker’s hiring. That complicated things somewhat. He couldn’t throw Mr. Henderson to the wolves when it was the Caruthers’ name on all the documentation. Well, Tucker had admitted his own folly in front of two witnesses and been summarily discharged. The shareholders would have undoubtedly preferred a scapegoat that was higher on the food chain for this snafu; however, Dr. Caruthers was confident he could work with what he had.

“It’s surprising he was able to do so much damage, given that he was just brought on to help the project meet deadline. I mean, he was barely here longer than a week.”

“A lot can happen in a week,” Mr. Henderson replied.

“So it seems,” Dr. Caruthers agreed. “I suppose that will be all today. Get your people busy on a fix for Project Jefferson. I want it by...” Dr. Caruthers hesitated. “Well, how long do you think it will take them to complete?”

Mr. Henderson smiled confidently. “I am positive they can get it done in four weeks.”

“Excellent,” Dr. Caruthers said. “Have it ready in two.”

\* \* \*

A young couple walked happily along the stone path, taking in the

sights of the island as they adjusted to the tropical heat. Kenowai was a tourist mecca, offering inclusive resorts or secluded getaways, depending on a traveler's preferences. Ahead of the couple, a tan man with dark hair and rippling muscles carried their bags. They hadn't bothered to ask, but the fellow was a native named Mano. He'd worked at this particular hotel for many years and carried the bags of many couples. A few times a year he'd also carried some new bride with panicked regrets into the highest levels of carnal bliss, but that was a dangerous hobby and one best observed only in small amounts. On the whole, he worked here because the owners were nice, the visitors cheerful, and on the rare occasion when he got to work the pool bar, it meant he didn't have to spend the whole afternoon sweating.

They drew close to their building, a several-story complex that looked out of place against Kenowai's unspoiled vegetative scenery. They were nearly to the double doors when Mano held up his hand to stop them. The couple obliged, unsure if there was some additional check-in procedure or quaint island tradition they needed to observe. Instead, they stood still as a cat walked across the path in front of them. It was the color of midnight across its entire body, except for the tail, which had a tip that was gold as sunlight dipped in honey. The cat paid them no mind as it skulked along, its eyes fixed on the world before it.

"Sorry, folks," Mano said with just enough accent to be charming. "Got to give right of way to the King of the Island."

The newlyweds stared at him for a moment, then began laughing at such an adorable concept. They went in and got their room keys while Mano set down their bags and noted what an appreciable bottom the woman possessed. He already had a feeling this was the kind of day that could end in trouble, but Mano had stayed out of trouble for a long time now and that was dangerous, too. Mano was firm in the belief that you had to visit trouble every now and then, like a needy relative, to keep it satiated. If you didn't visit it then it was likely to get lonely and come looking for you.

Outside, the cat came to a dune that overlooked the beach and took a seat. He stared out at the ocean, dreaming of all the fish that flew beneath its waves. The cat's name was Sprinkles, and the reason for that is a story within itself. The humans thought they were joking when they called him King of Kenowai. They didn't know it, but they weren't. Sprinkles was a cat and a king and one thing more, and it was this third part that nagged him as he gazed out from his dune. Something was gathering, some confluence of events that would lead to his island. He wondered what it would be, though the wonder was less of a worry than the natural curiosity inherent to all felines. After all, Sprinkles was sure he could protect his island from any threat.

You see, while most cats were certain they were of divine blood, if not



outright gods, Sprinkles was an aberrant piece of data in the equation. Oh, he had the same certainty as the others that he was cat, king, and godling, but Sprinkles was different.

Sprinkles was right.

\* \* \*

Clint sat in an Irish pub, nursing a beer that was dark as a storm cloud and twice as angry. Normally he would be sitting on a stool at the bar; however, the gentleman soon to be joining him insisted on a booth so they were less visible. If Clint had been pressed, he might have offered up a theory that working to be less visible only made you more interesting to look at. It didn't matter, though: the company policy said that the client was always right. This was less out of a desire to provide excellent customer service and more from the desire to be able to claim blamelessness should the client's preferred meeting method end in discovery. Not that what the company did was illegal, per se: merely frowned upon ethically.

A figure in a raincoat and a hat slid through the door of the pub, keeping its eyes to the floor and moving quickly so as not to draw attention. Of course everyone noticed it, but when they realized it was neither a deranged shooter nor a beautiful woman, attention quickly waned. There was a groan from the booth's boards as the figure settled its sizable heft across from Clint.

"You... are amazing," came a strangled voice from the poorly-concealed face. "You saved my job. My whole department."

"It's what we do," Clint said simply. "I'm glad it worked. Did you pad your schedule this time?"

There was an adamant nodding of the mystery man's head, one shake so vigorous it caused the hat to slip and nearly reveal the purple vein that bulged against the bald head. "I told him four, he gave us two, which is one more than we should need."

"Sounds like things are good then," Clint said. "Just be careful what you authorize for beta-testing in the future. The businesses who lost their e-mails were howling for blood over lost orders and documentation. Even we can only do so much."

"I understand." From within the jacket the figure produced a thin envelope and slid it across the table. "Your severance pay, as specified in your contract. To be honest, I'm surprised they agreed to it when they hired you."

"If your references are fantastic enough, they'll do anything to get you. Speaking of which, I trust we can count on you for a letter of recommendation and an amazing review when you get called?"

"Of course. Your company held up your end, I'll hold up mine."

"I think that's everything then," Clint said simply. "Would you like a beer?"

“No, thank you. I’ve spent the last month certain I was going to get fired. I’m spending tonight at home, celebrating with the wife.”

“Understandable.” Clint watched as the large man worked his way free of the booth and hurriedly shuffled out the door. He took another sip of his beer and looked at the check in the envelope. It was all there, of course. Corporations were always fastidious about contract adherence. That was part of what made a position like Clint’s possible. His official title was Freelance Consultant for Withersby Positional Solutions Incorporated. They specialized in bringing in employees just before bad news became known to the higher-ups in a company, and then proceeding to take the blame for whatever that particular brand of catastrophe entailed.

To put it simply: Clint Tucker was a professional scapegoat.

[Read the rest on Amazon.com](#)

## About the Author



Drew Hayes is an aspiring author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail.

He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

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# SUPER POWEREDS



# **Super Powereds: Year 2**

By Drew Hayes

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Cover by Barry Behannon ([barrybartist.com](http://barrybartist.com))

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## **Acknowledgements**

This one goes out to Gordon Korman, whose books taught me that laughter, emotion, and fun characters can all work well when paired together. Without those novels, I'm not sure where I'd be today, but I'm almost positive it wouldn't be writing. Thank you, for all you've created.

I also want to thank my beta readers for all the input and assistance. To E Ramos E, Galina and Charles, Priscilla Yuen, and Van Seunsom, your feedback helped take this whole thing to the next level. For realsies.

## **Foreword**

(A.K.A. Some stuff you should know)

Yowza, Year 2 already. For those of you who read Year 1, this section is pretty much old hat, so feel free to jump into the story. For those of you who haven't read Year 1, what are you doing? This is a series, you should start with the first book in it. Trust me. A lot happened. This book will still be here when you're caught up.

If, for some reason, you are set on starting here rather than at the story's inception, there are a couple of things you should be aware of. First off, this book was originally published chapter by chapter as a webnovel over the course of a year. That's why there are so many chapters, and why their individual length is shorter than what one might see in most novels.

Secondly, just a bit of fair warning, there is cursing, drinking, and other college activities in this novel. Nothing above an R-rating, but don't say I didn't warn you when the first F-bomb flies.

Lastly, I just want you to know I appreciate you picking up this book and giving it a shot. Whether you've been reading these works for years, or got this on impulse, I really hope you enjoy the story. It's been a blast to write, and there's still two more to come after this. So, with no more fanfare or explanations: Welcome to Super Powered: Year 2

## Prologue

Mr. Transport could smell honeysuckle through the rough cloth surrounding his face. He felt the sunshine beating down upon the black fabric, causing a light film of sweat to simmer on his skin. An insect landed lightly on his right hand, delicately straddling the steel cuff encircling his wrist. It was, by far, one of the nicest places he had been detained in the past month. From the tranquil way Mr. Numbers was breathing alongside him, it could be inferred the shorter man echoed the sentiment.

The black bag draped across Mr. Transport's face was peeled back suddenly, blinding him as the sunlight thrust into his eyes. After some moments of blinking, Mr. Transport gained the ability to make out shapes, and soon recognized that he and Mr. Numbers were in a garden etched in his memory for its vastness and beauty. The man sitting across the stone table from them was recognizable as well, though not for such aesthetic reasons.

"Care for something to drink?" Mr. Adair offered as he sipped his own cocktail. Today he wore a blue cotton shirt with white pants, and no shoes. He was at home and relaxing, not dressing to impress. Given the day's temperature, Mr. Transport wished he were similarly adorned, rather than entombed in his own standard wool suit.

A large man with tattoos on his face undid the cuffs shackling both him and Mr. Numbers. Mr. Transport exchanged a quick glance with his partner, but there wasn't much to communicate beyond the obvious. They'd spent the last several weeks being grilled and interrogated on their perceived failing from last spring. This, whatever it might be, was a welcome change.

"Gin," Mr. Transport said unabashedly. He certainly wasn't on duty, and he had no idea when an offer like this might come again.

"Water for me," Mr. Numbers piped up. Mr. Adair handed them glasses, pausing only to alter the liquid in Mr. Transport's, and then sat back in his chair.

"You two," Mr. Adair said calmly, "have done quite an impressive job of pissing everyone off."

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport merely sipped their drinks in response.

“Sincerely, it is quite amazing in its own right. Your immediate employers believe you incompetent at best, traitors at worst. Lander is also howling for your blood since you let three students slip away, but their protests are dulled by their own failings in the incident. You’ve angered nearly every person even remotely associated with you.”

“Nearly every person?” Mr. Transport asked.

Charles Adair looked away from them, redirecting his gaze to the impressive mansion that lay behind them. “As I have mentioned before, not only do I own a sizable portion of the corporation that employs you, but I also possess an arsenal of contacts with quite a bit of influence of their own. That is why you are here today, gentlemen. It took some doing, but I have wrangled myself the position of sole judge regarding your fates.”

Mr. Transport drank his gin a bit more enthusiastically, determined to see the bottom of the glass if it would be his last.

“On one hand, you two allowed my daughter, either through action or stupidity, to escape in a truly idiotic attempt to rescue her friend. The fact that she isn’t dead or being held somewhere could be taken as testament to a kind divine plan. On the other hand, Alice has returned from Lander with happiness in her eyes and a measure of pluck that is reminiscent of her mother. She has flourished there, and it is you two that I have to thank for putting her in the program.”

It seemed Mr. Adair was going to skirt over the fact that he had strong-armed them into that decision, a skirting neither of the captive men was inclined to bring to his attention.

“So, after considerable thought, I have reached a verdict regarding you two,” Mr. Adair said. “I am willing to overlook the lapse in judgment you showed and reinstate you in your post as guardians. However, I offer you this only on one condition.”

“Name it,” Mr. Numbers said.

“To quell Lander’s lack of confidence in you, a gesture of goodwill must be made. I happen to know they are seeking to replace the coaches who... let us say, creatively resigned. There is one man I know they are particularly hoping to take over George’s role, yet have had no luck in even locating, let alone convincing.”

“With Mrs. Tracking, I’m sure we can lend a hand,” Mr. Transport

offered.

Mr. Adair reached under the table and produced a manila folder. He slid it across the table where it stopped at Mr. Transport's fingertips.

"Finding him has been handled. It's the convincing I think you two can lend aid in. If you can talk him into taking the position, even if only for a year, you will be able to reclaim your former posts."

Mr. Numbers took the folder and flipped it open, reviewing its contents. "And if we can't?"

"Then you no longer have any additional help to offer," Mr. Adair said.

"We understand," Mr. Numbers said, snapping the folder shut. "We'll do it."

"Of course you will," Mr. Adair confirmed. "Now finish your drinks and get to it, boys. The clock is ticking."

\* \* \*

The elves clustered together, their ravaged ranks quickly dividing into scouts, lookouts, and defenders as their leader wracked his head for a plan. Elster Highrange, known as Elmer in the world outside, pushed a hand past the pasted-on ear and through his disheveled hair. He couldn't believe the way they'd swept through his troops, executing traps like they were five moves ahead and striking with such inhuman precision. When he'd taken over this role, Elmer had been told his predecessor had been a master of strategy, but he'd never really believed it. That was why he'd refused to yield his role as leader when the man had returned for the summer. That was why he'd been unfazed when the man took up the mantle as leader of the orcs. And that, in truth, was why he was losing so badly today. That... and the demon.

"Did you see it take out the battalion of five?" His troops were whispering and he didn't blame them. Practicality aside, a monster like what they had seen certainly deserved to be spoken of in hushed tones.

"I saw it take down the Cloudrage brothers. Those two were unstoppable, and it had them soaked in paint before they could finish drawing."

Elster tightened the grip on his own blade. His "blade" was in fact a foam bat that had been soaked in a slow-drying blue paint. The spongy

exterior was ridged, as were all his soldiers' weapons, so a blow struck was easily identified and impossible to deny. The orcs wielded a different pattern and red paint, the same color splattered the tucked limbs of some of his men. Of the three that remained, two were missing arms and one was on his knees, both legs taken in a scuffle with the demon.

"What was he like, Zithriel?" They asked him this again and again, but Zithriel had always only the same answer.

"All I saw was a flash of silver and all I heard was the whistle of his swords. After that I was down."

It was curious that the demon had left him alive. In his telling of the story, Zithriel had once remembered to include the fact that he dropped his own sword in surprise. Elster had wondered, ever so briefly, if perhaps this specter of death lacked the ruthlessness to attack an unarmed man. He'd curtailed those thoughts almost immediately. No one who cut such a swath of carnage could hold to high ideals.

"Men," Elster said firmly, trying to regain the confidence and subservience of his troops. "How fare we on all points?"

"Clear from the north."

"Clear from the east."

"Clear from the south"

"Not clear from the west."

Elster blinked. That hadn't been Armthimarge's voice. He glanced over to see his loyal lookout lying on the ground, red paint coating the fallen elf's neck where his throat had been "slit". The attacker must have been fast: Armthimarge hadn't even called out a warning. As Elster's eye took in the man who had slain Armthimarge, that fact made more sense. He stood short for an orc, and though the war paint obscured his face, he seemed to wear a curiously placid expression. He wielded a blade in each hand, dripping flecks of red slowly pooling on the ground at his feet. A shock of silver hair and a set of blue eyes that would have looked more at home on an elf decorated his head, and as he stepped forward Elster had no doubt who this warrior was.

"The demon," Elster whispered. The next time he spoke, it was with fury, hope, and desperation all rolled together like a burrito of command. "Attack!"



His men rushed their target; they still held enough respect for their leader to obey orders. Besides, there were fifteen of them left and only one of him. No matter how good this beast was, not even he could take all of them.

The demon twirled his blades once, then stepped forward to meet the first attacker. Yllsigard struck furiously, coming in overhead with all his might to power through the demon's guard and take at least a limb. He swung true, but the demon slid around him like spilled mercury, taking Yllsigard at the base of his neck before he could recover from his missed blow. Rartical and Phiong came at the demon together, flanking him to split his attention. Their gambit proved futile, however: the demon simply pushed to Phiong's side and dispatched him, then turned his attention on the remaining warrior.

Elster began backing away. The sum force of his remaining men were currently being sliced through; he needed an escape plan in the unlikely event this madman managed to hack his way to the last.

A wet, squishy sound splashed in his ear as a blade took his right arm, the one currently gripped around his weapon.

"Your first mistake was underestimating me," said a voice from behind Elster.

Another blow cleaved away his left arm, before it even had a chance to reach for his lost hilt.

"Your second mistake was backing away when your men charged. A true leader does just that. He leads."

One final blow took Elster's legs, and he kneeled as was mandatory with the loss of those limbs.

"And your biggest mistake was forgetting that while a team may possess a valuable asset, that warrior alone does not make up its entire force."

The voice spoke louder now, declaring its orders to Elster's men.

"Your leader has had all his limbs sundered. You are completely surrounded. Throw down your weapons now and surrender, or face the inevitable."

The elves looked around nervously, realizing that orcs were materializing out of the forest and that they were now vastly outnumbered. They glanced over and saw Elster on his knees, paint dripping from all four appendages. They set their blue paint-soaked bats on the ground and put up

their hands.

“Your compliance is appreciated, and will be met with mercy,” said the voice, its source strolling around Elster’s left and at last entering his field of vision. He was a hefty orc, yet he moved with a strange confidence on this uneven terrain. He surveyed the domain well, eyes alert, taking in every detail. Only after he was certain that each elf was both unarmed and guarded did his vision leave the battlefield to regard his opponent general.

Elster looked up into the eyes of the man who had beaten him soundly and indisputably. He swallowed his pride, thought of his men, and spoke with as much grace as his throat would physically allow.

“Well met and well played, Growlthberz. You are victorious.”

“I am indeed,” said the orc. “But the game is over now, Elmer. You can just call me Hershel.”

Elmer nodded and slowly climbed to his feet. One thing was certain: whatever his name might be, Elmer would certainly be yielding to this man’s leadership come next summer.

\* \* \*

The man was dressed in an all white suit, with his light hair trimmed short and his nails perfectly manicured. His whole outfit, like everything he deigned to wear, had been custom made just for him. He saw no qualms with such excessive funds being channeled toward wardrobe. After all, he had the means now, and he’d lived the life of self-denial for plenty long enough.

He checked his gold watch briefly, gauging how long he should stay before making his exit. His client was clearly satisfied, there was no denying that. She’d stripped nude in front of the mirror as soon as the procedure was done, not even a fleeting thought given to modesty. Mrs. Hadingsworth was still examining herself even after several minutes, scouring every inch of her now-taut flesh for signs that something had been missed. She would find none. The man clothed in white was exceptional at his job. For what people paid, he had better be.

Eventually Mrs. Hadingsworth collected herself, threw on a nightgown that was now far too big for her lithe and youthful form, and joyously shook his hand in thanks. He accepted her gratitude, but only because he had already accepted her sizable sum of money, and made his departure. Mrs. Hadingsworth had a landing strip on her property, so the man

had left his private plane there rather than deal with an airport. It was as he ventured across a well-maintained garden that a tall man wearing square spectacles stepped out from behind a rose bush. The man in the white suite was hardly surprised: the bespectacled man had been trying to reach him for some time now and he was not known for his tendency toward giving up.

“Zero,” he greeted.

“It’s just Blaine these days,” said the other man, adjusting his glasses. “Dean Blaine, if I’m at work.”

“Noted.”

“What are you going by now?” Blaine asked.

“The same as before. I do have something of a reputation associated with that name after all.”

“So it’s still Hallow, then,” Blaine said.

“Indeed.” Hallow stepped to the side of Blaine and began walking toward his plane once more. He knew this wouldn’t deter Blaine, but it would force him to get to the point.

“No small talk?” Blaine asked, turning and briskly catching up.

“I have a schedule to keep. Please cut to the quick of it; you’ve been seeking me for weeks now. Don’t waste the opportunity.”

“Very well. I want to offer you a job.”

“I decline,” Hallow said immediately.

“Don’t you even want to hear the details?”

“No, I can safely assume it has something to do with two of your teachers going rogue back in spring. You want me to fill one of their positions, and I have no interest in doing so.”

“You have a lot to offer,” Blaine pointed out. “No healer has ever been capable of doing the things you can.”

“Which is why I make a tremendous amount of money doing it for the wealthy,” Hallow pointed out. “So much, in fact, that there is no possible way Lander could offer me comparable compensation. I doubt you could even afford what I’d normally charge for this meeting.”

“I suppose I should thank you for speaking with me pro bono then.”

“Of course. We’re old friends after all,” Hallow said, choosing to skim past the barb hidden in the comment. “Listen, Blaine, I understand your position, sincerely I do. You’ve had two people you trusted betray you, not to mention word has leaked out about you harboring Powereds in your program, so you need to fill those empty roles with people you know you can count on. Since I fit both that qualification and possess world renown, I would be an excellent candidate to take on the task. Unfortunately, I have no interest in teaching, or in taking a pay cut. I hope you can understand.”

“I can, though I’m disappointed.”

“Chin up, old friend. There are others from our Class of Legends who you can still try.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Blaine acknowledged. The truth was that of the few that remained active, most had turned Blaine down already. Ionics was happily married and raising her third child. Bullrush was a successful coach in the Super Athletics Association, his football team having won four championships in the last decade. “I’ll let you get to your flight, sorry for the delay.”

“Not at all,” Hallow assured him. “It’s always nice to chat with a classmate. One day when my life slows down a bit we should get together and catch up.”

“Of course,” Blaine agreed, knowing full well Hallow wouldn’t be slowing down anytime soon. Not with his particular talent so vastly in demand.

Blaine pressed his fingers to his temples as his comrade continued walking through the garden, never sparing a glance back at the man he called friend. Blaine had known it was a long shot going in, but that gave him little comfort. He’d exhausted nearly all other available options, leaving him with only one that he considered an even longer shot. Still, he had to try.

\* \* \*

Nicholas tapped the felt gently, a subtle gesture that conveyed all he needed it to. While he was normally one who spent his time wiling and beguiling at the poker table, today Nicholas was taking it easy and just playing some blackjack. He wouldn’t keep his winnings, of course: money won from the house just came out of the family pot, which was another reason

he preferred trouncing tourists. Still, there was something relaxing about letting go of the need for guile and subterfuge while taking in its place the pleasure of tracking a myriad of numbers.

He leaned back in his chair as a seven of hearts was laid onto his stack, placing his total at twenty. The dealer was showing eight, so Nicholas made the easy call and decided to stay. He wore grey slacks and a black button-down, and a gold tie hung loosely around his neck. Nicholas worked hard to convey an image of disheveled elegance.

Every now and then Nicholas felt the urge to adjust the sunglasses he was no longer wearing. He'd get a new pair soon; even if his dorm mates knew the reason he wore them, they still provided excellent camouflage from the rest of the students. Aside from which, they were a rather ingrained portion of the Nick character, and Nicholas was loathe to put him through major modification mid-performance. For Nicholas had indeed elected to continue his career at Lander for another year, even with his big secret leaked to the world. There was so much to learn, and so little of it from the classrooms. Besides, his dorm mates had proven loyal beyond the degree of rationality in the events of last spring. That meant he could count on them to help him get by, despite his comparative lack of ability.

Those four were trusting, dedicated, and strong. They would make excellent pawns, possibly ones so good he would be able to play his charade all the way to the end. He just had to go slow, and take things one move at a time.

The dealer flipped his face-down card to reveal a jack, leaving him unable to hit on the eighteen he now held. Nick and two other players at the table raked in their winnings. Nick methodically set out a two hundred dollar bet for the next hand. By his count, the deck was about to get very hot. One of the waitresses stopped by, dropping off a new gin on the rocks for him. Nicholas gave her an acknowledging glance then turned back to the game. She was new here; he'd remember to get to know her better later in the evening. After all of his pressing business was attended to, of course.

One move at a time indeed.

\* \* \*

This man wore all white too, but his was not a designer suit custom tailored to his frame. It was a jumpsuit, one with a number stitched on the front and a series of tracking devices woven throughout it. The regular

prisoners still wore orange to be easily spotted, but those like him were decked out in white. Some said it was in recognition of what they once were, or what they could have been. The official reason was that it was a safety measure to allow the guard to immediately distinguish between his kind and the regular inmates. Not that this man was given much time to socialize with the others.

The man had dark hair, cut short, and a small soul patch above his chin. He'd briefly considered growing the full goatee to match his incarcerated persona, however he'd decided that would be fringing on the terrain of melodrama.

His cell was composed of rocket-proof plastic walls that afforded no privacy. After some lobbying he'd been successful in gaining a curtain around his toilet area; however, even when sitting it only came up to his shoulders as far as coverage. The most impressive feats of engineered captivity in the cell couldn't even be seen. The air ducts that ran overhead filtered through a series of pressurized chambers before they brought fresh oxygen to his cell, and another set of them drained off the old air. This allowed for the whole system to be shut down at a moment's notice should its inhabitant opt to go gallivanting. A similar system was used for the toilet and for the one entrance to the cell.

On this particular day, a rare event occurred. The entrance swung open to reveal a tall man wearing spectacles, one the prisoner knew all-too well.

"Zero," said the inmate. "This is a pleasant surprise."

"Just Blaine these days. I left that name behind several years ago."

"I know what you mean. These days I just go by 48935."

Blaine clucked his tongue. "I'm afraid that's no good. We're far too good of friends for such a dismissive title. How about Sean?"

"No one has used that one for a long time. Okay, Zero, call me Sean."

"I told you it was Blaine."

"I told you it was 48935. Besides, for such a 'good friend' this is the first time you've visited me in here. You know, since you arrested me."

Blaine walked slowly over to the bed and sat down on the atrociously thin mattress. "Can you blame me? Or any of us? You went from an honored Hero to a common thief."

“To be fair, there is nothing common about me or what I stole.”

“A fair point. Nuclear secrets, famous works of art, closely guarded industrial patents. You had quite a run,” Blaine admitted.

“Until Zero caught up to me,” Sean pointed out.

“Until I caught up to you. You were a thief, Sean, and I was still a Hero. You had to know the way things were going to end.”

“A man can always hope. That is a right that not even prison can take away.”

“If you sincerely believe that then you should be thankful for where you ended up. I’ve seen prisons that most certainly do have the ability to take away a man’s hope,” Blaine told him.

Sean spread his hands. “So consider me thankful. Let’s celebrate the occasion by getting to the point.”

Blaine hesitated. This next part was delicate, not only in what he needed to say, but in how much he could safely let out while their conversation was being monitored.

“I know you think I wasn’t listening, that night when I dragged you in. I was, and I’ve had a lot of time to dig into it since then. I’m not saying I believe your reason for all the stealing, but let’s just say I’m not as skeptical as I once was,” Blaine said.

“Wonderful; that and a cigarette will get me a cup of coffee in here,” Sean spat back.

Blaine reached into his suit jacket and produced a few folded pieces of paper. He unfurled them and kept them in his hands for the moment.

“I know you haven’t been privy to the grapevine of our world in here, so I’m assuming you haven’t heard the news,” Blaine said. “Five of my students from last year were subjects of an experimental procedure. One that gave them enough control to be reclassified from Powered to Supers.”

Sean’s whole body stiffened, but his voice remained calm.

“You don’t say.”

“I do say. Their secret came out at the end of the year, yet they have elected to return despite the less than welcoming sentiment echoed by their

fellow students.”

“Sucks to be them.”

“Yes. It sucks even more because two of my employees, teachers no less, decided to kidnap a pair of them at last year’s end. Though the students were safely recovered, that leaves us in the position of having two spots to fill. One has been conditionally handled, however I’m still in the market for the services of an experienced Super who I can trust.”

Sean laughed at this, visibly and freely. “A job? You’re here to offer me a job? And how would that work exactly? Are you going to keep me by your side twenty-four hours a day so I can’t slip away? Or better yet, maybe you’ll build me my own cage out there so the students can learn from me while I’m pinned up like a side show.”

Blaine shook his head. “No cages, no monitoring. You’d have to live on campus, of course, but you’d be free to roam the town as you like for your off time. You have five years left of your sentence. You can spend them here, or in my employ.”

“You’ll never be able to sell that to the higher ups,” Sean protested.

“I already have. Despite what you may think, since our time apart I’ve garnered quite a few friends of station who trust my judgment. If I say you won’t run, they’ll believe me.”

“Let’s come back to that point then. Trust. You need someone you can trust. But you and I aren’t exactly close friends anymore. Even assuming I’m not still bitter enough to try and attack you, how do you know I won’t run at the first chance I get?”

Blaine reached over and grasped the inmate’s forearm. Their eyes met, Blaine’s burning with intensity like phosphorous.

“Because I trusted you enough to check out your reason for stealing. And, while I haven’t found proof, I also haven’t found anything to contradict your claim.”

Sean pulled back his arm and broke away.

“How does that stop me from running?”

“Because these five students are not some mystical batch using a resource that only existed once. They are a trial run, to test for long term side



effects. In six more years, if they are still healthy and functioning, the procedure can be approved and used on other Powerededs. Even then, the number of applicants they initially accept will likely be very small. Getting someone into that program will require a lot of influence. Now tell me, who do you think has a better chance of opening that door for someone: a recently released thief, or a rehabilitated and respected professor of the Hero Certification Program?”

“You spin a pretty story, Zero. One problem: that’s a lot of ifs. If it works. If they get clearance to accept more people. If I can earn favor with the right people. Don’t get me wrong, it’s very tempting. You’re just trusting a lot to faith,” Sean said.

“I’m aware,” Blaine acknowledged. “However there is one part I left out. Whether the program expands or not, there is one very concrete opportunity for you to do good.” Blaine held out the papers he’d been clutching. Sean tentatively took them in his spindly fingers and began to read. It wasn’t until he flipped to page three that his body language softened visibly.

“Is this...?”

“It is,” Blaine confirmed.

“My god, have I been in here that long? Last time I saw her she didn’t even come up to my hip.”

“A lot can change in fourteen years,” Blaine said.

“I suppose you’re right,” Sean acknowledged. “So this was your ace in the hole.”

“No; I knew you would have eventually come for the other reason. No matter how slim the chances were, you would have taken them regardless. That’s the kind of man you are. This was just to help the decision along. I’m on something of a time crunch,” Blaine explained.

“Well played, Zero,” Sean said. “I suppose you’ve got yourself a new professor.”

“In that case, you will refer to me as Dean Blaine at work and Blaine in our off hours. This is a different world than our old one, and I don’t need to muddle the two.”

“Agreed, but on one condition,” Sean stipulated.

“That is?”

“You let me keep the picture,” Sean said, gently waving the papers where a file photo was inked onto the third page.

“Deal,” Dean Blaine agreed. “I suggest you prepare yourself. You’ll be leaving this place in the morning.”

“I’ll have the maid pack my things,” Professor Sean Pendleton replied.

Dean Blaine stepped out of the room, and Professor Pendleton plopped down on the still-awful mattress where 48935 had sat mere moments before. He gazed at the poorly-pixelated image and was carried off, out of his cell, to a glimpse of the happier life he’d once had. In his wondrous drifting, a single phrase escaped his mouth.

“I can’t believe how much you look like her.”

\* \* \*

There was a whoosh of air and a jerk as they began moving forward.

“Are you sure this is a good idea?” Mary asked.

“You’ll be fine. Yeesh, when did you become such a chicken?” Alice replied.

“It isn’t a matter of reason; it’s a matter of fear. I’ve spent most of my life on the ground among nature.”

“You did fine on the mountain,” Alice pointed out.

“There was ample earth beneath me.”

“What about when I flew with you?”

“That’s different,” Mary said. “I trust you more than I trust a team of poorly-paid workers commanded to slapdash wooden planks together in the hot summer sun. Besides, I was a little preoccupied at the time.”

A loud, rhythmic series of clicks began echoing from underneath them.

“Come on, try to enjoy it. This place was your idea anyway,” Alice said.

“It was this or another day touring the shops. I chose the lesser of two evils. Plus, I like riding the teacups.”

“We’ll go on them again after this,” Alice offered. “I just can’t believe I never knew you had this phobia.”

“It isn’t a phobia.”

“Didn’t you just say it was a fear not rooted in reason?”

“Yes I... but it... shut up.”

Alice laughed as the wind began to pull at her hair, their crest nearing its apex.

“Sorry, I just never get to see you flustered. All this time and it turns out roller-coasters are your hidden weakness.”

“At least one of us is enjoying this,” Mary said, her grip tightening on the metal bar pressed against her lap.

“I have a feeling we both will be by the time it’s over,” Alice said. “And besides, I told you if you rode it with me I’d go a whole week without bringing you along shopping. So don’t act like all the sacrifice is on your end.”

“Fine, fine. How much longer are we going to climb up, anyway?”

As the words crossed her lips their car began tilting forward, revealing a lush landscape along with a winding road of wood and steel.

“Off-handedly, I’d say not long,” Alice quipped before they plunged forward, all communication lost in the chaos of joyous screams.

\* \* \*

The man lounging on the beach’s white sands was wholly unremarkable. Yes, his broad shoulders and strong frame hinted he might have once been a man of some physical prowess, but the streaks of ivory salting his once dark hair assured any observer that this man was well past that stage and into the one that involved daytime television and ranting at today’s youth. He wore a garish Hawaiian t-shirt despite the fact that he was in Tahiti, a pair of shorts, and no shoes. He owned a pair of flip flops for when he ventured into town, but with his home only a few paces away from the water, he rarely found the need to don them. He sipped a homemade margarita and watched the waves roll in as he kept a lazy eye trained on the book he was reading. As lax as he seemed, he was not startled one iota when a pair of suited men appeared a few feet away from him.

“Boys,” he said by way of greeting.

“Hello,” Mr. Transport replied. “How are things Mr. V-”

“Carl. I’m retired now, so it’s just Carl.”

“Of course. Carl,” Mr. Numbers said. “This is a lovely estate.” Mr. Numbers surveyed the houses behind him, all of them at least three-story and perfectly maintained, as was their landscaping.

“Say what you will about our company, they do have an excellent retirement plan,” Carl noted. He stuck a small scrap of paper in his book and set it down. He suspected this might take a while and he didn’t want to lose his place.

“I look forward to it,” Mr. Transport said, gazing at the pristine waters delicately moistening the sugary sand beneath his feet.

“I did too. And I’m enjoying it now. Which begs the question, what brings you two around? I’d welcome you for a visit, but I somehow doubt the policy on vacation time has become so generous.”

“Sadly, no. You see, we are here to offer you an impressive opportunity, one that would only be fitting for one with your years of tactical and-”

“None of that, Numbers. Just spit it out,” Carl cut him off.

“Fine. You’ve been offered a teaching role in the Lander University Hero Certification Program,” Mr. Numbers said succinctly.

“Thanks but no thanks. I’m already retired and set. Why would I need to take another job?”

“You don’t,” Mr. Transport agreed. “But we sort of need you to.”

Carl gave a more scrutinizing glance to his guests. Despite their professional appearance, they looked haggard. Not just the gaunt look of ones overworked: it was that of ones who had been truly put through a wringer of shit and were scarcely holding it together. Carl had seen that look before. He’d almost worn it himself a time or two. The company had an excellent retirement package, but surviving long enough to get it was sometimes akin to walking a minefield whilst blind and drunk.

“You boys messed up.”

The duo nodded.

“How bad?”

“Not terrible,” Mr. Transport replied.

“But bad enough,” Mr. Numbers tacked on.

Carl sighed and took another sip of his margarita. He really did love it out here. The ocean would still be around when he came back. It looked like the same couldn’t necessarily be said for Numbers and Transport.

“What kind of time frame are we talking about here?”

“You can accept as little as a year to fulfill our purposes,” Mr. Numbers informed him. “Though once we give you a full briefing, you may opt to stay longer.”

“Why is that?”

“Let us simply say that things have gotten very uninteresting on the Lander campus these days,” Mr. Numbers replied.

“That a fact? All right then, boys; for you I’ll come spend a year.” Carl stood from his sand-coated chair and dusted himself off lightly. “That said, since school likely doesn’t start for a few weeks, how about you two come inside? We can have a couple of drinks, and you can tell me just what is so interesting out in California.”

“I’m not sure we’re permitted time to relax and drink,” Mr. Numbers said.

“Nonsense. I haven’t signed any paperwork yet, and I refuse to do a favor for mere co-workers. I will only do one for friends. So, if anyone asks, you can honestly tell them this was a necessary step in my recruitment,” Carl said.

“Touché,” Mr. Numbers said.

“Now then, Transport, let us get you behind the bar. I’ve never had a Mai Tai that can compare with yours.”

“It would be my pleasure, sir,” Mr. Transport replied.

## 1.

Vince's back popped as he stretched after the car ride. It wasn't a terribly long trip, but it was long enough to make the former nomad feel cooped up and trapped. Thankfully, he'd held it together and now he gazed at his reward: Lander campus, lush in the late summer as students scurried about its grounds. He didn't recognize any of them, which was to be expected given Lander's size, but he did recognize the looks in some of their eyes. Confused, excited, filled with wonder, and trying to piece together where the building they needed was, these were clearly freshmen. Vince would have offered them some assistance; however, he had other duties to first attend to.

Vince pulled his own backpack from the trunk of Ms. Daniels' station wagon, then helped Hershel with his luggage. Hershel paused their unloading process when his mother approached.

"Be sure to take care of yourself," Ms. Daniels said as she held her boy tight and gave him a kiss on the cheek.

"Don't worry, Mom, I'll be careful," Hershel assured her. Vince was next to receive one of Ms. Daniels' powerful embraces, though mercifully he was spared the cheek kiss that accompanied Hershel's.

"Thank you for everything, ma'am," Vince said politely. "I really appreciate you letting me stay in your home this summer."

"Such a proper young man. You watch out for yourself, too. I expect you both back safe and sound when the year ends."

"I'll do my best," Vince said. Ms. Daniels accepted this for the honesty it was and stepped back into her car. With a quick crunch of tires and small cloud of dust, Vince and Hershel found themselves once more alone in the world of Lander.

Vince tossed his backpack on his shoulders and scooped up a few of Hershel's bags. "It's good to be back," he commented as they began the brief walk to Melbrook.

"No joke," Hershel agreed. "You think we're the first ones?"

"Since Alice actually lives in California and Mary was staying with her, I'm sure they beat us back," Vince said, answering the question Hershel had clearly wanted to ask. Hershel turned a bit red in the ears with

embarrassment, though why he felt the need he wasn't sure. He and Mary were boyfriend and girlfriend. She'd even visited twice over the summer's span. So while there was no rational reason for him to turn red at the accusation of missing her, the tips of his ears burned all the same.

They came upon Melbrook shortly, its familiar brick facade a strangely comforting sight. It had been freshly pressure-washed and all but shone in the afternoon sun, welcoming back those who called it home with warmth and comfort. The boys buzzed in through the front door, then walked through the hallway door and entered the common room to find they were the last arrivals.

Alice hopped off the couch and dashed over, giving Vince then Hershel powerful hugs that only a girl with her height and arm span could manage. Mary was subtler, giving Vince a quick half hug, then sidling up to Hershel and taking his hand in hers as she stood close. Mary was never one for gratuitous affection, but the understated action spoke volumes of how she'd missed her man.

The final body to shamle up from its sprawled position on the couch was a sandy-haired youth with a new pair of sunglasses, somewhat more fashionable than last year's, seated on the bridge of his nose.

"I knew you'd come back," Vince said, shaking his friend's hand.

"Believe it or not, after living with you nut jobs, Vegas felt... boring." Nick spat out that last word, wiping his tongue across his teeth to scrape away the bad taste that accompanied it.

"Whatever you say," Vince agreed. Nick moved on to give a quick shake of the palms to Hershel as well, and just like that, all five of the Melbrook students were reassembled.

"So when did you guys get in?" Vince asked.

"Mary and I made it this morning, Nick only beat you two by about an hour," Alice informed him.

"Cool, so have you gotten to talk to anyone?" Vince asked. "I spoke to Will and Thomas briefly over the summer. They weren't exactly happy with us, but I think we're okay with them."

"Alex harbored no ill will at all," Hershel added.

Alice shook her golden locks to the negative. "We weren't as close

with the others as you guys were, and we haven't really been able to run them down and talk things out today."

"Why not?" Hershel asked.

A well-built man in spectacles stepped into view from their kitchen.

"I'm afraid I'm to blame for that," Dean Blaine said, striding across the room and taking a seat in one of the area's many chairs.

"You didn't let them leave?" Hershel asked.

"I prefer to say I strongly advised against it until the rest of you had arrived. You see, we have much to talk about, and I would be remiss in my duties if I didn't give you a comprehensive idea of what to expect in this new school year," Dean Blaine explained.

"So what should we be expecting?" Vince asked.

"To put it bluntly: adversity," Dean Blaine replied.



## 2.

“Things have calmed down a bit since your departure,” Dean Blaine elaborated. “Unfortunately, that has also given people time to truly grasp the implications of your existence. To say I received some complaints regarding your enrollment would be a significant understatement.”

“They don’t want us here?” Of them all, only Vince could be genuinely surprised by such a statement.

“At the very least, a vocal minority of them do not,” Dean Blaine said. “I, however, do. Regardless of what you started life as, you are currently Supers. You have also shown the kind of determination and talent needed to enroll in the sophomore year of the HCP. Any information beyond that is extraneous and irrelevant so far as your admittance goes. With that said, I feel you should all be braced for a far less welcoming atmosphere than you found last year at Lander.”

“We know some of our friends are sticking by us,” Hershel said.

Dean Blaine nodded. “And I’m sure more will in time. Right now you aren’t the people they knew, but rather a representation of one of the greatest unspoken fears in Super society. Eventually, some of them will begin seeing you for the individuals you are once more.”

“But not everyone,” Alice said somberly.

“No, Ms. Adair. Not everyone. In the meantime, I suggest you stay close, work together, and trust in the allies you still have. That mindset will be very important this year, but you’ll get the details on that tomorrow. Now, on to logistics. I’m sure you’re all wondering about Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport. I’m... well, not pleased, but not angered, to report that they will be returning to Melbrook as your guardians.”

There was a general expression of pleasure and relief for the five to learn that not only had the duo survived, they were also being reinstated in their post.

“The other professors and I will be keeping an eye on you as well, for extra security. I’m afraid I have to report that despite several interrogation sessions, George has yet to divulge any information about who he was delivering Mary to, or why. That means for the moment we have no idea if

you all are still in danger, so we've chosen to assume you are," Dean Blaine continued.

Nick raised an eyebrow. "So you're going to be spying on us? Creepy."

"Now, now, Mr. Campbell. There's no such thing as privacy in the HCP facility anyway. We'll just be more actively watching over you five."

"We appreciate it," Mary said politely.

"No trouble at all. I think that outlines most of what you needed to know immediately. People are angry, you're still assumed to be in danger, same people living here as last year. Yes, I'd say that covers the high notes." Dean Blaine rose from the chair and adjusted his glasses. "Oh yes, one more thing. Last year you were not able to use the lifts to enter the HCP facility and instead had to rely on Mr. Transport. I'm not sure what reason he gave you for this, but the truth is that it was because I wasn't sure any of you should have that access. I didn't quite know what to expect of you and I certainly didn't trust you."

"Yeesh, thanks, jerk," Nick quipped.

"The point I was driving at was that this year you will find them quite functional for all of you. You are free to come and go at your own leisure. Welcome to the Hero Certification Program," Dean Blaine concluded. He exited through the front door, letting the cold steel lock shut with an audible thud behind him.

"Well, that was a real upper," Nick said in the ensuing silence.

"Forewarned is forearmed," Vince replied, picking up his own bag once more and heading toward the boys' side. "I need to unpack then maybe we can all grab dinner."

"Oh yeah, me, too," Hershel said, hurriedly gathering his own parcels. "Where should we go? I bet the dining halls are open."

"Of course they're open, tomorrow is the first day of class," Nick pointed out. "We got here a day earlier last year for freshman orientation and they were already serving up what we'll choose to refer to as food."

"Then let's do that," Hershel said as the door sealed behind him.

Nick turned to the girls. "Should I point out to him that we're

currently pariahs to a small but very powerful portion of the population, and we have to keep our abilities here, along with our HCP enrollment, a secret? You know, the sort of situation that warrants avoiding densely-packed areas of students where we're likely to encounter an antagonizing entity that could blow our cover to purposely get us booted?"

"They'd get themselves thrown out too," Alice pointed out.

"Not if they were smart about it. Besides, even if they did, I'll bet you money one of the other colleges would take them in. They'd be hailed as legends for keeping the name of Hero pure by knocking out people like us," Nick said.

"Maybe so," Mary agreed. "But I for one refuse to spend the rest of my time here shaking in fear of what some jerk may or may not do. I'm going to live my life, and if anyone decides to interfere with that... well, I suppose at the very least we can make them work for it."

"Easy for you to say," Alice noted. "You can actually follow through on that threat. Nick and I are somewhat less able to take a toll on any would-be attackers."

"Speak for yourself. I plan to curse anyone who tries to drum me out with terrible luck at sex for the rest of their lives," Nick said.

Both girls turned to look at their sandy-haired companion.

"Can you actually do that?" Alice asked.

Nick shrugged. "Sex comes from confidence, and if someone thinks they're cursed, they'll sabotage themselves. So sort of, I guess."

"Seems a bit roundabout for you," Mary said.

"I'll think of something. I guess I'd better since it seems you folks are set on going about business as usual," Nick said.

"That we are," Mary agreed. "So let's go help the boys and then get ourselves some sloppy joes."

Alice groaned audibly as they headed out of the common room, her stomach already protesting its impending culinary assault.

### 3.

“Feels strange to be wearing grey,” Nick commented as the Melbrook students filtered into the large lecture hall alongside the rest of the non-freshman HCP students. The black-uniformed newbies had gone through their meeting the day before; this morning had consisted of their battles for initial ranking. Evidently watching those fights was quite the spectator sport for the sophomore and older students, but the quintet had decided that it was best to avoid such condensed crowds until they had a better grasp of where public opinion was leaning.

It hadn’t taken long to answer that question. Just in their journey from the surface to the locker rooms for changing into uniforms and now into the hall, they’d lost track of the number of dirty looks and furtive whispers buzzing about. There had been the occasional outright glare, as well as the all-too-rare supportive smile. It seemed the overall consensus was that no one knew quite what to make of them. For the moment they were being regarded with the same apprehension one showed the bearded woman at a carnival: curiosity, disgust, and superiority, but not outright malice. It was actually much better than it could have been.

All five sat near the top of the stadium-style seating arrangement, unsurprised to find the once occupied spots around them quickly emptying. They were near the end of the procession, so the abandoners had only moments to relocate before Dean Blaine stepped to the podium positioned in the center area and addressed his audience.

“I’ll keep this brief,” Dean Blaine began, adjusting his glasses without noticing. This was not a speech he looked forward to giving, but it had to be done. “Normally you are all only called together like this for emergency announcements. I want to put your mind at ease and assure you we are not under any imminent threats. This meeting is to discuss the replacement of two of our staff.”

A quick buzz whipped through the crowd; the majority of them had only heard garbled rumors about George and Persephone, even if most claimed that they were privy to knowing the “real deal.”

“I’m certain that all of you are at least partially aware of the situation, and I want to apologize that it is only now I can tell you something concrete. Due to the delicate nature of this scenario, a full investigation was warranted

before any statements of certainty were issued. That investigation has been concluded, and it is now my duty to inform you that both George and Persephone attempted to kidnap one of the freshman female students last year.”

The buzz spiked in both tempo and volume. Many glances were tossed around, though it was only the sophomores who threw most of them at the five students sitting near the top.

“I won’t be going into the details, predominantly because so many of them are still yet to be fully verified, but you all deserve to know that piece of truth. They committed a crime, betrayed the trust placed in them as educators, and have been replaced. You will meet your new teachers in their respective classes; they’ve requested I allow them to make their own introductions rather than trot them out in front of you all. I realize that this is difficult news, as many of you have grown to trust and respect your teachers over the years. To that regard we are offering counselors on site for the next few months. Should any of you feel the need to talk, their services will be freely available upon request.”

The buzz had dulled to a simmer, the initial shock of finding out such outlandish rumors were true giving way to the reality of what was being said. Two of their coaches had gone rogue and had tried to steal a student away in the night. After the first wave of disbelief passed through them, many of the students were hit with the terror deep in the pits of their stomachs as a uniform thought echoed across the landscape of their minds: “It could have been me.”

“I want to assure you that we’ll share more information about this incident with you as we obtain it. For right now, that is all. The sophomores need to report to the gym for this year’s orientation. Juniors will have theirs in three hours, and of course seniors already know what to do with their day. If you have any questions about this, please take note of my office hours and know that my door is always open to each of you,” Dean Blaine concluded. “You are now dismissed.”

“That wasn’t so bad,” Vince said. “I wonder why they didn’t have the freshmen in here too.”

“Kind of a ‘duh’ on that one. The dean just had to admit two of his own staff went off the reservation big time. The last thing the new kids need to hear at their welcoming is that the staff they’re supposed to be trusting with their lives have a recent history of kidnapping and treachery,” Nick told him.

“They don’t, not the ones that are left. The only two who were guilty are gone,” Alice said.

“You’ll forgive me, but until I know for sure what the motivation behind that fiasco was, I’m going to just go ahead and assume everyone here has a motive for wanting us kidnapped or dead,” Nick replied.

“That seems like a cynical overreaction,” Hershel said.

“Not really,” Nick shrugged. “I pretty much assume that about everyone anyway.”

“Well, Nick’s advocacy of paranoia aside, he has a point,” Mary said. “First year is already scary, the last thing they need is someone tossing on yet another thing to be afraid of.”

“Yeah, between the masses of people being drummed out, the mystery of what the classes are like, and the challenges for rank, there is already plenty to keep a freshman on their toes,” Vince agreed.

Nick snickered. “You don’t see the humor here, do you? We’re in the exact same boat. We don’t have any idea of what this year’s syllabus of examinations will be like. We’re no better off than the freshmen.”

“No, there is one big difference,” Hershel corrected. “We know we can make it through a year. We know we’ve got what it takes to survive the cuts.”

“Pretty trivial difference,” Nick said.

Hershel smiled at him. “Everything is trivial, right up until you need it. Now let’s go see what fresh horrors this year has in store.”

#### 4.

The grey-uniformed population of the gym had thinned slightly from its black-clad incarnation. Though Vince recognized all of his once-friends amidst the sophomores, there were definitely some faces missing. Faces of people whom he'd seen struggling and working and fighting right alongside the rest of them. Faces that wouldn't be seen again in the HCP. It was a solemn reminder that there was a long road ahead, with plenty of opportunities to wash out. Vince shook his head and focused on the task at hand. There were six individuals clustered with Dean Blaine in the center of the room, all of them quite distinctive and unfamiliar.

"Today, we are going to talk about majors," Dean Blaine announced once everyone had gathered within range of his voice. "Freshman year is used as a trial by fire. We drum out those who can't cut it and get those who can into shape. From sophomore year onward, things will be working a bit differently. For starters, we're going to be having only a single hour of gym together each day. The rest of your time will be spent in your respective classes. Here at Lander, as well as in all schools participating in the HCP, we offer six distinctive courses designed to evolve you into field-ready Heroes. I'll let the professors introduce themselves and their courses in a moment; right now I just want to touch on the program as a whole."

"This year you will each be enrolled in three of the six courses. These were chosen by determining the areas you can best grow, as well as your performances in last year's final exam. Come your junior year, you will be allowed to continue in the two areas you show the most promise, and in your senior year you will devote all of your energy to a single area of focus. This final area is considered your specialty, or major, in the HCP. It will help determine what sort of Hero you'll be and give you a good idea of where you should apply for internships."

"Internships?" Vince whispered to Alice with a raised eyebrow.

"Yeah, don't you know? Once you graduate you have to intern under an existing Hero for two years before you can work on your own. It gives real world experience," Alice hurriedly whispered back.

"That is, of course, a long way down the road and will only concern a fraction of you," Dean Blaine continued. "There is something else relevant to this year, however. Last year we focused on learning to fight one on one,

which is a core concept for any Hero. However, one of the great advantages we have over criminals is our ability to work together in a trusted and cohesive unit. For that purpose, tomorrow you will be split up into teams. Aside from your performance in your classes, there will be several team-based challenges throughout the school year. Your performance in these will, of course, affect whether or not you join us for the junior year curriculum. The details for that will be covered at the commencement of tomorrow's gym period along with the team selection, so for now I will defer to your professors so that they might introduce themselves."

Dean Blaine stepped back, opening up the floor to whoever wanted to come forward. The first one to take the step was the most unassuming. She was an older woman, clearly in her sixties or seventies from the wispy grey hair and mild hunch in her spine. Already diminutive, the curve in her figure made her border on tiny. Her voice betrayed none of the frailty of her form, speaking loud and firm with the confidence only a wealth of experience could provide.

"It is a pleasure to meet you all. My name is Esme Stone, though it will be Professor Stone to you lot. I teach the subject of Focus, and those of you who enter my class will emerge with a new level of understanding regarding the inner workings of the self."

She stepped back into line, allowing the next speaker to come forward. He was a tall man with a broad chest and jet black hair, only his temples showed his age with a few patches of white.

"My name is Professor Hill," he barked in a loud, determined-to-be-commanding voice. "I teach the subject of Control. The privileged few who gain access to my class will be taught to command external forces on greater levels than they ever thought possible."

The next figure to step forward was easily the most distinctive. It was covered with cloth strips on every possible exposed part of its skin, making it look like a mummy wearing clothes and a large cloak. A sizable sword hilt protruded from over its shoulder, and it walked like a snake just begging for a reason to strike. It shocked many of the students to hear a female voice emerge from the wrapped face unmuffled. It was high-pitched and delicate, but not delicate in the sense of fine china or hand-crafted porcelain. It was delicate like an unstable explosive.

"My name is Professor Cole. I teach the course on Weapons. Those of you unfortunate enough to get me will be beaten, cut, burned, sliced,



skewered, and snapped. You will get strong, and those who make it to the end might even emerge as warriors.”

The next figure stepped forward quickly, a pretty woman in her mid-forties with hair somewhere between brown and red, as if it wasn't quite able to make up its mind.

“My name is Professor Baker, and I'll be teaching some of you Ranged Combat. I feel like my course's name pretty much explains it all.”

She stepped immediately back in line, leaving only two figures remaining. They exchanged glances briefly, and the taller of the two took a bounding step forward.

“My name is Sean Pendleton,” said the man, his dark hair hanging forward, slightly dangling into his eyes. “Though I suppose from now on it is Professor Pendleton. I've been brought here to teach you in the art of Subtlety. Much like any other art, all I can really do is help develop what already exists. Some of you have the touch, while others don't. I look forward to seeing what you can do.” Professor Pendleton gave a grand bow before retreating to the line, leaving only one figure remaining.

He took his step forward and gazed out at the students. He was an older man, probably only younger than Professor Stone. His powerful frame was largely concealed under his gaudy Hawaiian shirt, but he carried himself in a way that made it evident he was not a man to be taken lightly.

“My name is Professor Fletcher, and in addition to teaching Close Combat, I'll also be running the gym sessions and overseeing the team events. For the slower of you that means that yes, I am new here and was brought in to replace George. Now, this leads me to the unfortunate disadvantage I suffer meeting you in your second year. Normally, I would have trained you all up and seen your fighting prowess on a finite level. That would let me gauge what to expect from many of you in the year to come, as well as earning your respect by demonstrating my skill as a fighter. Since I missed that opportunity, I'm afraid my most practical remaining option is simply to test you all with my own fists and get a sense of your strength from that.”

The rest of the professors and the dean began backing away from Professor Fletcher. He cracked his knuckles lightly and gave the class an oddly reassuring smile.

“Anyone who needs to shift, do so now. In ten seconds I intend to fight you all at once.”



## 5.

“You’re sure you want to start things off like this?” Professor Cole asked; Professor Fletcher still hadn’t pieced together how she spoke so clearly through all that cloth.

For his part, Carl Fletcher nodded his head and took a sip of his tea. The dean’s meeting would end soon and the students would be filing into the gym. Right now the professors were all dwelling in the break room, discussing plans for their first introduction.

“I’m sure,” he said. “I don’t agree with a lot of George’s old methods, but he and I do see eye to eye on a few points. Having faith and respect in the people trusting you is definitely one of them.”

“Perhaps, but given the atmosphere and recent events I’m not certain showing the class that not even all twenty-eight of them at once can beat you instills the sense of security you think it does,” Esme said, sipping her own mug filled with strong black coffee.

“It’s not ideal,” Carl conceded. “But if we’re talking ideal I wouldn’t be here and George wouldn’t be a turncoat. We can’t afford to treat them with kid gloves because of his and Persephone’s mistake. The students still have to learn, and to do that effectively they need to believe we have something to teach them.”

“Which begs the question, why are you the one squaring off with them?” Blake Hill asked, his tone respectful and his eyes suspicious.

“Three reasons,” Carl replied. “First, I’m the Close Combat class teacher, so it makes sense that I’m the one to fight them. Second, I’ve got a lot of experience in bringing down Supers without doing lasting damage. And finally, because I’m the new guy. If I can beat them all so easily, they’ll think you more experienced folks can kill them with a thought.”

“A great idea,” Professor Pendleton contributed, “with one caveat. We’re talking about twenty-eight kids with pretty exceptional skills. Are you sure you can beat them?”

Carl gave an easy smile and finished the rest of his tea.

\* \* \*

If last year had taught the students nothing else, it was to take seriously a threat of violence from one of their teachers. Professor Fletcher had scarcely finished speaking before Stella had adopted a more chromeish veneer and Hershel had gulped down the contents of his pocket flask. Others in the class took fighting poses, or brought themselves up to full alertness before Professor Fletcher took his first step. Not that it helped much.

Most of the students only saw the man in the brightly colored shirt vanish before their eyes. A select few were still conscious to see him reappear on the other side of the crowd, or rather on the other side of the sea of collapsed bodies. They were also privy to the light show that streaked the air, wild currents of electricity hanging about like floating tinsel, searing the eyes for a moment then fading away into oblivion. Of the seven still standing, only Chad and Sasha had been able to see everything that happened.

“Not bad,” Professor Fletcher said. “I expected to get more of you with that.”

“E-Electricity,” Sasha panted. Most of the others had remained standing due to their natural resistances. She and Gilbert, on the other hand, had actually dodged his attacks, a task which had taxed her speed and reflexes to the limit. “You turned into electricity.”

“Quite,” Professor Fletcher confirmed. “You see, of the known Supers in the world, approximately seven percent fall into an elemental manipulation category, such as the ice user over there.”

Michael’s armor of ice was melting on the ground as he lay passed out on the cold cement floor. Frozen water was an excellent barrier from physical assaults, but it came up lacking as an electrical insulator.

“Most of these can only generate or shift a certain kind of element. Of that seven percent, about a quarter have total mastery of their element. The ability to sense it, create it, control it, and alter it in any fashion they see fit. Now, of that quarter, a mere ten percent are so powerful that they can give their physical bodies aspects of their element. Stony skin, boiling touch, and even a thing like lightning speed becomes possible.”

“Yeah, yeah, we get it, you’re the cream of the crop, you rise to the top,” Roy said, shaking off the last attack. It had been a strong charge, but he’d remained standing. He was somewhat pleased to note that of the men’s top five ranks, only he and Chad could boast that claim. “Big whoop, we’ve heard it before.”

“The point I was trying to make, good student, is that even that ten percent of a quarter of seven percent is still classified under me. Because I don’t just assume my element, I can actually turn into it,” Professor Fletcher concluded. “So let’s see, still standing we have two resistance- and strength-based fighters, one absorber, one super speeder, one density controller, one rubber man, and one short range teleporter. Decisions, decisions.”

## 6.

Gilbert readied himself to leap again the moment the Professor disappeared. He knew he couldn't win this way, but if he kept mobile long enough he might run out the clock until one of the combat capable people took him down. Professor Fletcher lurched forward and Gilbert teleported through the world, arriving at the rear of the gym, hopefully a long way from both sight and mind. A jolt of energy surged through his body, scrambling his wits and sending him crashing to the floor.

"Teleportation is a useful tactic," Professor Fletcher informed him. "But the limitation is that you still think and react at human speeds. Which means someone who moves fast enough can easily sneak up behind you. In the future, try to think in terms of multiple jumps so as to confuse your opponent."

Sasha stood on the balls of her feet. She could see when he transformed and see how the mass of energy moved. She alone could outmaneuver him; she alone might stand a chance. This was how she would start her year: not as the freak's ex-girlfriend, but as a warrior on par with the new fighting teacher.

The surge of light and power flashed toward her, quick, but not so quick that she wasn't able to slide out of the way. He was very fast but as she twisted her body around she knew he wouldn't overtake her. She kept knowing that, right until his large hand closed around her arm.

"You are extremely fast," Professor Fletcher complimented. "But unlike me, you still have too many physical limitations. Ever with your sped up reaction times, your bones and muscles can't match lightning. Which means you can't match me with dodging alone; you should have used a little offense as well." It took an impressive charge to drop the girl with pink tips in her dark hair, but she tumbled to the ground like the rest eventually.

Hector took advantage of the distraction to charge forward. He'd been waiting since he got to the HCP for a match up like this. For all the electricity this old man might be packing, there was nothing he could do against Hector once he turned his body to living rubber. Not only did it give him amazing protection from bludgeoning attacks, but it rendered him an insulator. This was his fight to win. He reached the professor just as Sasha fell, letting fly a mean left hook toward the wrinkled face. His fist connected only with air, as

he found the teacher standing to his side.

“Quite bold, and I can see why. To the untrained, this match seems heavily weighted in your favor. Of course, that ignores the fact that your defenses are ill-suited against attacks that slice or pierce, but even more importantly, it overlooks a basic piece of engineering knowledge,” Professor Fletcher said. He wrapped the rubber boy in bear hug and held on tightly. “Namely, that there is no such thing as lightning proof, only resistant.” The gym practically glowed as Professor Fletcher coursed electricity through Hector’s body. He stopped well short of a point that would have seriously melted the rubber composition but made certain to leave the boy a limp pile upon the floor.

Roy didn’t bother with getting ready or running forward. The guy was too fast to see. His only hope was to wait until he slowed down enough to attack and then give him a good wallop. He braced his legs and tightened his right arm. He was still ready for the attack when the tremendous voltage stuck him in the chest, sizzling through him and sending him into the realm of dreams. This same line of attack brought down Violet as well, the two sprawling out in different locations but with similar styles.

“If I was a speeder, then they would have selected a viable strategy,” Professor Fletcher acknowledged as he came to a stop. “Those are made of flesh and bone, and as such have to slow themselves to attack with accuracy. As a being composed of energy, I’m able to deliver as much juice as I need while simply going through them. Which brings me to you two.”

Vince stood ready, his body open to the charge of power that would soon be delivered. Chad was more relaxed, his body centered and brain running at full tilt. He couldn’t maintain such a heightened state all the time, but by over-clocking his brain, he was able to think and react at the level of a super speeder.

“The top of the class and the leader of the group that brought down George. Do you know why you two are the only ones left?”

Neither boy took the bait, merely waiting for his next movement.

“Because I haven’t gotten to you yet.” Professor Fletcher was suddenly standing by Vince, who readied himself for the influx of energy. What he received instead was an influx of punches to his head and torso as the professor knocked him dizzy.

“You have a great defense against energy,” Professor Fletcher

complimented as he delivered a right to Vince's temple that sent the silver-haired boy toes up. "Sadly, that doesn't help against a fighter with superior skill. In this case I did warn you that people at my level can take on aspects of our element, such as speed, without shifting into it. Remember, just because I have a preferred method of attack doesn't mean it's my only one."

Professor Fletcher turned his attention to the last remaining student. The highest ranked student from the men's category, unofficially recognized as the strongest fighter in his whole class. He rushed to Chad's front, sending out a few punches to gauge his speed. Chad dodged about expertly, sending back a few jabs of his own.

"You're impressive. You have the power and endurance of a classic strength fighter along with the perception and reactions of a super speeder. I bet there are even more techniques locked away in that head of yours. Unfortunately, I have a class coming in for gym soon, so I don't have time to see just how far you can go. Some other time, perhaps."

In a whirl of movement, Chad found himself encircled by electricity, a crackling fence that barred him from any escape. The circle drew tight, eventually ensnaring its prey completely.

By the time Chad's unconscious body joined the others on the floor, Carl Fletcher was standing a few feet away, wiping the small beads of sweat that had dripped down from his salt and pepper hair onto his forehead.

"Whew. I am getting old. That almost left me winded," he said.

Professor Pendleton, standing amidst the others who had acted as audience to the assault, struggled to keep the look of amazement off his face as he spoke to the now nearly empty room.

"Is this a good slow clap moment? Because it kind of feels like a good slow clap moment."



## 7.

Vince rubbed his head as he and the others walked among the late summer foliage that decorated the Lander campus. He'd been healed, of course. They all had. But somehow he felt like something still smarted. Were Vince the introspective sort, he might have considered the possibility that it was his pride.

"Yeesh, I feel like I'm still walking funny," Nick complained, his own gait easily on par with the others despite his protests. "Next time I'm pinning a note to my shirt: 'Do not let Ed heal.'"

"Who is Ed?" Alice asked.

"One of the junior year healers. What's wrong with Ed?" Roy answered and asked.

"His power just speeds up the body's natural healing to light speed. I prefer the ones that make it like it never happened," Nick explained.

"You want some cheese with that whine?" Mary said snidely.

"No, but I would like some original content in your insults," Nick shot back. "I'm just saying, electricity can have long term effects. What if it had screwed with my nervous system, or worse, dulled my rapier wit?"

"We'd finally have proof of a just and loving God?" Alice ventured.

"Ha. Ha. Just for that I'm not listening to your votes on what to watch for our welcome back movie marathon," Nick snapped.

"Oh no, please, please, please be joking," Mary's soft voice implored.

"Come on, how else do you want to celebrate our return to Lander than by engaging in our traditional form of revelry?"

"Literally, I mean literally, anything else," Alice said.

"Fine then. Whipped cream orgy it is."

"Is it sad that I'd almost prefer that to more slasher flicks?" Mary asked.

"At this point, no," Vince agreed as he opened the Melbrook front door. The five students piled in and down the hallway, entering the common

room to find a set of unexpected guests awaiting them.

“Good afternoon,” Mr. Transport said, flashing them a wide smile. Mr. Numbers was more subdued in his greeting, merely offering a curt nod to his charges as they meandered into view.

“You guys are back!” Vince cried happily. Despite the dean’s assurance, Vince had remained worried about what repercussion the Mr.’s would face for their role in Mary’s rescue.

“Of course,” Mr. Transport confirmed. “I’m sorry we’re a bit late, there were a few final loose ends to wrap up before we were able to return. I trust you had a good orientation?”

“Good? Why, it was downright... shocking.”

It’s hard to say who threw the first light punch into Nick’s shoulder for that awful pun, but it was easily observable that everyone joined in before he cried out for mercy.

“It was interesting,” Mary reported more factually. “Looks like second year is a lot different from the first.”

“In more ways than one,” Roy tacked on.

“So we’ve been briefed,” Mr. Numbers said. “It will be hard. Try to keep up.”

“What Mr. Numbers means to say is that we have faith you five will make us proud and all do well enough to make it to third year,” Mr. Transport hastily added.

“Sure,” Mr. Numbers said, in a tone that one could take as an agreement, were they feeling particularly generous.

“Well, glad as we all are to see you, we were already deep in a discussion about how to spend our evening,” Nick said, steering the conversation back toward his original goal.

“Uggggh.” The groan came from both the gathered students and, if one were listening quite carefully, was slightly augmented by a small contribution from the pursed lips of Mr. Numbers.

\* \* \*

Carl sat in his new office, a formerly paper-cluttered mess that had

been scrubbed clean of all documents in the course of the recent investigation. He drank a glass of water and eyed the small white pills in front of him. It was ludicrous to him that he could transform into living lighting, fight off an entire room of young bucks, and yet his doctor was still lecturing him on the importance of monitoring his cholesterol. It seemed like a horrible prank perpetrated on him by the cosmos. Still, Carl Fletcher was a pragmatic man, so he swallowed the pills along with a mouthful of water and grimaced at the bitter taste.

A light hand knocked on his door, then slid the wooden barrier open without waiting for a response. Carl glanced up to see a tall man with dark shaggy hair waltz in and plop down in a chair positioned directly before the desk.

“That,” Sean Pendleton said, “was truly stupendous. I mean, a masterful display of skill and power woven together in a tapestry of ass-kicking.”

“Thanks,” Carl replied, taking another draw from his water.

“A sight like that, it speaks to a lifetime of experience. Certainly years spent in active combat, not to mention extensive training beforehand.”

“They don’t exactly hire rookies to teach here,” Carl deflected.

“Oh no, certainly not. In fact, generally speaking, only Heroes with exceptional pedigrees and pristine records are even considered for these positions. I say generally because I believe you and I are exceptions to that rule. You see I, in case you weren’t aware, am a convicted thief on the grandest of scales. And you, well, you are a no one,” Sean said.

“Aren’t you just a charmer?”

“I don’t mean it as an insult, I meant it literally. See a talent like yours coupled with the skill you showed would hardly go unnoticed, even in the world of Heroes. But I’ve never seen or heard of any Hero with your particular talents, and I even went to the trouble of doing some digging after the spectacle. You aren’t a criminal either; I certainly would have heard of someone like you running in that circle. So that leaves you as a nobody. Which presents quite the conundrum.” Sean leaned forward at this point and lowered his voice. “Because, you see, I know why I was chosen to replace Persephone. And given the situation at hand, I can only conclude that Dean Blaine tapped you for precisely the same reason.”

“Trust,” Carl surmised, his own tone matching the low audibility of Sean’s.

“Right on the money,” Sean said. “Dean Blaine is in quite a precarious position, and as such seems bent on surrounding himself with personnel he can count on. Now, I know why I’m perceived as loyal. You, however, remain something of an enigma to me.”

“While everything you’ve said is true, I fail to see how it’s any of your business,” Carl replied.

“Simply put? You and I were both brought here from the outside after a fantastic snafu. Now, while he would never want to admit it, two top employees going so far off the reservation must have shaken Blaine’s faith in his staff. And rightly so: we still have no real idea what the point of their little after-hours field trip was. So a logical person would be forced to assume that there is more going on than what is presented on the surface.”

“You’ve just said a lot without getting to the point.”

“My point, you cretin, is that in a program where every human cog is a potential Judas, the only people we can safely trust are the dean and one another. So I’m proposing we get to know each other a bit better, given the shaky alliance we find ourselves thrust into.”

Carl sighed and finished off his cup of water. At this rate his doctor would have him on stress medication, too.

## 8.

Vince sat on one of the many benches that littered the Lander campus, looking up at the stars. The wooden slats were hard against his back and the night was still a touch too summery to be truly comfortable, but to the former wanderer these inconveniences weren't even noticeable. He was too caught up in thought, too enraptured in the sentiment that was washing over him, one he had felt so rarely he didn't even fully understand what it was. Vince was experiencing the warm glow of coming home after time away.

He hadn't really believed it, hadn't let himself believe it, for the whole summer. Every ring of the phone, every letter in the mail, each piece of contact that arrived would certainly inform him that he and his ilk were not welcome to return. That they were being booted to make room for the real Supers. That his wonderful but brief fever dream of becoming a Hero was coming to an end.

The call never came. Still, he didn't trust it. He was sure Melbrook would be boarded up when they arrived. He was certain that the lifts would refuse them entry into the underground area. He was positive the other Supers would band together and drive them from the subterranean halls. Today was the first time that fear had finally vanished. Strangely enough, it was only after getting his head punched about by Professor Fletcher that Vince finally felt like a true HCP student again. He was reveling in that feeling.

The others had probably gone to sleep, but Vince had been unable. That was why he was out on the campus in the dead of night, body stretched out on a bench that was too small and looking up at a universe that was too big. Were he another student, he might have been concerned for his safety. Lander was a secure place; however, there is nowhere that is truly safe to be caught unaware in the middle of the night. Vince, however, had no such concerns, and nor should he have. After all, Vince Reynolds was not a regular person.

Vince Reynolds was a Super.

\* \* \*

Alice Adair's leg flew through the air and locked into position, matching the figure on her television nearly perfectly. She took a step down on the extended leg then snapped out the other one. She followed this up with

a series of rhythmic punches then stepped back.

Clad in yoga pants and sports bra, Alice would have looked more appropriate in an upscale gym than her actual location, her bedroom. Playing on her TV screen was a well-built man in his early forties, taking her through a set of attacks and withdraws supposedly designed to emphasize precision over power: in other words, a fighting system built on the premise of women lacking upper body strength. This man made five separate tapes, each containing a workout that lasted about an hour. Alice was on the third one so far tonight. Over the summer she'd done all five every night. For a normal person it would have been ridiculously taxing. For someone who'd been physically conditioned by Coach George for nine months, it was well within the range of doable.

Alice's arms, always slender, were now beginning to possess a shape more distinctive than simple cylinders of pale flesh. She was gaining tone and muscle across her frame, and it was shaping her into more than the pretty teen she had once been. Alice Adair was becoming beautiful. Not just for her fitness, but for the increasing grace with which she moved and the surety with which she carried herself. It was nice; however, it was nothing more than a side-effect.

Alice had always been pretty. Alice had always known how to carry her body to send certain signals. Alice had always been dainty. Frail. Weak.

She let loose another flurry of kicks in the solitude of her room, images of last year's fiasco sending adrenaline through her veins. All she'd done, all Alice had ever been able to do, was run away. And she hated it.

Alice stepped forward and dealt out a series of deft jabs. She wanted to be stronger. She needed to be capable. Alice Adair didn't want to run any more.

\* \* \*

Roy lifted another set of weights, this time focusing on his biceps. At this time of night, the gym down in the HCP was nearly deserted, only an occasional upperclassman walking by to cast a curious glance at him. Let them look; Roy couldn't give less of a shit if he tried.

Roy pulled the weight slowly upward, coming to a rest at the top of his chest and then beginning the downward descent once more. Roy sometimes felt like his right arm made the trek easier than his left. He wondered if it was him trying to compensate, to imagine his right arm was

making amends for its uselessness in the fight against George. If so, it needn't have bothered. Roy's body had failed as a whole that day; no one part had to bear the blame on its own. Roy had fought a variety of opponents in his life, starting well before Lander. Here the quality had increased, though. He'd seen with Chad how lacking his skills were, how much refinement he needed to play on the same field as the big boys.

His strength, however, that had never been called into question. Even against the number one ranked student in the class, it was only that Roy couldn't make contact with him, not that the fist making the contact lacked the power to hurt. So Roy had spent the year focused on developing that skill set, on learning how to fight and knowing he was already strong enough. Until the day he wasn't.

George had shrugged off his best attacks. All that work, all that time learning to connect, and he found himself lacking in the damage department, the one area in which he'd always been unstoppable. There was no denying the truth. He had been, at best, an inconvenience to George. If not for Vince's help, Roy didn't even know if he would have been that. Vince, who at the beginning of the year had been nothing more than a twig who couldn't light a cigar. Nick had done the planning. Alice had been the speed. And Mary, Mary had saved them all, despite the fact that she'd originally been the one in peril. That only left Roy, who realized he was, ever so slowly, getting passed by.

Roy set down the free weights and headed for the bench. He had to have it all. He had to fight with his brain and hit with his body. He needed to be better. He needed to be faster. He would not falter again.

And next time Roy Daniels met with George, he was determined not to need anyone's help to knock the metal head cleanly from his shoulders.

\* \* \*

Mary was actually asleep. She'd had quite a long day and anticipated another tomorrow, so after a light dinner and a warm shower, she'd plopped down into bed and set sail for the shores of dreamland. If only the slumber she'd found had actually been peaceful, it would have been quite a pleasant night. Sadly, such was not the case.

\* \* \*

Nick clicked on a new link, a story containing an eyewitness account of a man made of lightning wreaking havoc in Minnesota ten years ago. It was, in all likelihood, a complete waste of time, but Nick hadn't gotten this

far without being thorough. Still, he was a bit surprised. Nick would have thought that given the showy abilities of Professor Fletcher he would have been the easiest to find information on.

That title had actually gone to Professor Pendleton, it had taken Nick less than a whole minute to find the opening segments of his fascinating story. The convict aspect was somewhat interesting, especially given his previous renown, but it wasn't particularly useful. Someone else would raise that point in class; it didn't need to be Nick Campbell. Besides, Nick wasn't interested in extortion material or dirty laundry. The six folders lying on his bed weren't filled with the family secrets of their subjects. They were stuffed with the limited data he'd managed to procure so far.

Having last names wasn't all that helpful since they would have used different handles during their Hero days. A few of them, Professor Cole especially, had distinctive appearances. Nick managed a touch of good luck with that alone. He'd know more soon; all that was required was patience. Once he saw their powers, tracking down information would be worlds easier. And Nick intended to do just that. He wanted to know every nuance of their abilities, every weakness they might possess, even when they'd first known they were Supers. Nick wasn't strong, or fast, or particularly intimidating. He would never be the kind of person who struck fear into the hearts of his enemies just by stepping onto a battlefield.

Nick did know, that is to say he truly understood, the value of information, however. And that merely goes to show how misplaced the fears of others were, because that trait alone made Nick Campbell one of the most dangerous men in all of the school.



## 9.

“Teamwork,” Professor Fletcher said, his strong voice echoing through the gym and landing upon the receptive sophomore ears. “Teamwork is our greatest advantage. Teamwork is what gives us an edge over the Supers who break the law. Teamwork can only come from trust, which can only come from not suspecting constantly that your teammates are looking to screw you over. That’s a gift only the good guys get. Nearly all Heroes have been, or still are, part of a team. There’s a reason for that. It’s a system that works.”

The attention of the students was well captivated by Professor Fletcher. Aside from the trouncing he’d given them the day before, he had a natural charisma that people responded to. Some of the more experienced faculty at Lander immediately recognized it as the decisiveness and confidence that came from having commanded one of the very teams he was talking about. It was the aura of leadership, and his last few years spent lounging in the sand hadn’t dulled it one bit.

“For that reason, this year you will see an emphasis on teamwork. In fact, you will be assigned to a team today and that will be your group for several events throughout the year. While you’ll attend classes as individuals, you’ll also be expected to take those skills and integrate them into the cooperative effort you’ll be building. And just so you know off the bat, this year’s final to qualify for advancement to third year will be a team event.”

There was a soft murmur of excitement amongst the students. Usually they didn’t know this much about their tests going in.

“Now since I did mention trust, normally we allow everyone to pick their own teams. We name some of the top ranks as captain then have them choose their partners one by one. Yes, we realize this leads to people picking their friends and we’re fine with that. Some captains do well with a thought out, coordinated strike team. Others choose people they can trust and depend on no matter the circumstances. I’ve seen the records and I can tell you both strategies are viable under the right circumstances. That’s what we normally do. But this year’s class isn’t exactly normal, now is it?”

There was an uncomfortable squirming from some of the students and unmasked glares from others. It seemed the collective attitude was somewhere between awkward and angry, which was still far better than

Professor Fletcher had initially expected.

“That’s what I thought,” Professor Fletcher said. “All right then, let’s deal with the elephant in the room. Five of your classmates were Powered before they came here. Some of you are fine with that. Some don’t care. Some are liberally pissed off. There are probably even some of you that don’t know how you feel yet, and that’s okay. I’m not here to make everyone feel warm and squishy inside about this new development. What I am here to do is make sure we have four teams with good composition so that the match-ups result in legitimate learning opportunities. I somehow doubt that the teamwork will really be popping if each team has a few members that generate controversy and conflict just by existing. To that effect, this year we’re making a modification to the process. The four Captains will be Mary Smith, Chad Taylor, Shane DeSoto, and Britney Ferguson.”

Britney looked surprised, though she was one of the few. Despite the humble personality of the girl and seemingly non-combative nature of her ability, she’d placed highly in both last year’s midterm and final. She was resourceful, quick-witted, and determined under pressure, the perfect candidate for leading a team of fellow Supers.

“Now then, rather than forcing anyone to be on a team they have opposition with, we’re making things simple,” Professor Fletcher continued. “Roy Daniels, Mary Smith, Nick Campbell, Alice Adair, and Vince Reynolds will all be clumped into a single team.”

“Didn’t see that coming,” Nick mumbled under his breath. He actually agreed with this strategy, even if he hadn’t been able to help himself from imagining all the possible team combinations he could build from this selection of Supers. He’d crafted a few doozies too, but he was confident this team could do pretty well. Depending on who else they got, of course.

“For those of you keeping count, you’ll remember that the teams will be composed of seven each. That leaves this one short two members. So, instead of forcing anyone to get picked via the standard process, we’re just going to give the spots to people who want them. Anyone who is willing to work with these students, pasts as Powered now known, please come step out from the line,” Professor Fletcher instructed.

It was a harsh move, admittedly, forcing people in this compact of a social sphere to publicly take sides with the outcasts. Professor Fletcher deemed it necessary, not only because they’d end up labeled as that by being on the team anyway, but because it would create a shared sense of being

hated. There were few things to bring a group closer than by making them feel that their members were the only ones they could count on.

The first one to step forward was a lanky boy whose brown hair had grown shaggier over the summer. Had Hershel been there, Alex would have flashed him a smile as he moved his body before the rest of the class, but since it was Roy in attendance, Alex instead focused on looking stoic. Few people were surprised; after all, the delusional telepath was barely better than a Powered himself. Of course he would side with them.

Stella, Violet, and Thomas followed suit. They'd discussed it the night before and they'd decided to support their friends whenever they could. In truth, however, Thomas was strongly hoping not to get chosen for their team. Not because of lingering resentment, but because he very much wanted to face Vince in battle again. Vince had beaten Thomas once, and Thomas wanted to test his progress against those who had bested him.

Will felt his foot drift forward, then pulled it back in line. He had no problems with the group, and he would have happily served alongside his friends. That wasn't viable, unfortunately; he needed to be in the same group as Jill and she would never take that step forward. He felt bad, and he fully intended to explain later, but his mind was set. Family came first.

Professor Fletcher was about to tell Mary to take her pick when one more figure gently glided forward. It was a small one, easy to miss in this crowd of large bodies and egos, but its advancement sent a ripple of surprise throughout the students remaining behind, as well as the ones standing forward.

Camille, for her part, tried to look nonplussed as she felt the stares of her class pile on top of her. Her neck became flushed and her hands started to tremble, but she kept all such nervousness off of her face. There would be time for cowardice later; now there was only the task at hand.

"More than I thought there would be," Professor Fletcher commented. "Mary, take your choice of two."

"I, um, I'm not sure," Mary said. She hadn't expected to be handed this responsibility, and wasn't prepared to make a strategic decision that would affect all of her comrades for the rest of the year in the space of a few seconds. Fortunately, Mary's particular talent kept her from being alone in her head, and even more fortunately there was a brain more cunning than hers actively lobbying to be heard from behind its stoic, sunglass-clad face.

“Camille,” Mary said, trying to sound sure of herself. The healer had been a relatively easy call; every team would have wanted her. It was the second choice that Mary was a little surprised by.

“And Alex,” she concluded. Mary wasn’t sure why Nick wanted someone who was essentially a weaker version of herself; however, she trusted his judgment in these matters. She’d just be demanding an explanation once they were away from prying eyes and ears.

“Okay, then, you seven cluster together,” Professor Fletcher said. “Everyone else, back in line. The other three Captains to the front. We’ll start based on rank, lowest going first, then up, and so on until all teams are formed. You’ll have a couple of minutes to talk, and then I’ll be giving out class schedules. Starting on Monday, you’ll be showing up for gym together then going to your assigned lessons. Team training takes place on your own time, so I’d advocate making some plans this weekend to find days that work for everyone. Just my advice, take it or leave it.”

None of the students were so thick-headed as to imagine there was actually a ‘leave it’ option on the table. Their final exam would take place with this group. Training was top priority in every one of their minds.

## 10.

“So, I guess we’re a team now,” Alice said as the seven clustered together. All across the room the other groups were circling up as well, having a quick chat and handling formalities while everything was still fresh and new. They were trying to adjust their mindsets, going from seeing each other almost exclusively as rivals to regarding one another in the light of camaraderie and mutual goals. The transition would be somewhat tumultuous in the majority of cases.

“Great to have you guys on board,” Vince said cheerfully. He shook Alex’s hand and slapped him on the back in a half hug. He did the same with Camille, albeit far more gently. It’s fortunate that doing so turned her face away from him, because Camille’s blush and expression would have made him think he had seriously injured her.

“Glad to be with you,” Alex said. “I have to say I was a little surprised you picked me. I mean, Thomas and Stella and Violet are all really strong fighters.”

Mary glanced at Nick, who took it upon himself to field the question.

“That they are,” Nick agreed. “But as the good professor pointed out, one of the core points of teamwork is trust. Now, while their stepping forward means the world to us, you’ve spent more time hanging out with us last year. You were also the first one to tell Hershel that you didn’t care about the whole Powered thing. To put a point on it, the five of us have experience working together, which is an advantage. Adding a sixth person who shares in some of that experience is worth vastly more to us than just another heavy hitter.”

“I’ve got that department handled,” Roy bragged, flexing a not unimpressive bicep. “I have to tell you, the one thing that surprised me was when the little lady here joined us.”

“Definitely,” Alice concurred. “I never expected to get the only healer in class with us. What made you decide to work with us, Camille?”

Camille let out a low squeak barely discernible to human ears. Luckily, Vince already had his own theory about her decision of addition.

“She’s good friends with the other three. I guess they all had the same sentiment toward helping us,” Vince said. He turned to Camille and gave her

a reassuring smile. “Thank you, by the way. I know someone with your ability could have had their pick of teams to work with.”

“No, I... I’m happy to be here,” Camille said, her soft voice piping up with more enthusiasm than she’d expected. She really was happy, too, that much was clear to everyone with training or telepathy. Alex already suspected the actual reason, but it was Mary who proved to be the more curious. So much so that she opened up her own mind and listened in to Camille’s thoughts for a moment.

“Whoa,” Mary said, taking a step backward and shaking her head. Whatever she’d been expecting, she hadn’t expected it to come with that much force, that much feeling. It was crazy that such a meek girl could be ratcheted up to that level of intensity.

“What whoa?” Alice asked.

“Oh, um, just whoa, I’m really excited about our team,” Mary lied lamely. “I can’t wait to get together and do some training.”

“Nor should we,” Nick leapt in. “We have a weekend before us, so I say we do a little team building event.”

“I swear to god, if you say the words horror movie I’m going to forcibly remove your baby-making equipment,” Alice said.

“Perish the thought,” Nick replied. “No, I was thinking more along the line of an outing, an excursion if you will. Something fun for us all to do together. Shall we say tomorrow night?”

“What did you have in mind?” Alex asked.

“A classic training technique to help us learn to work fluidly and seamlessly,” Nick told her. “Wear something nice and meet at Melbrook around eight.”

“I’m terrified, but curious,” Vince admitted.

“Have no fear, I guarantee a night that will culminate in both training and entertainment,” Nick assured him.

“I’m pretty sure that’s the part that terrifies him,” Alice said. “Well, that gives us tomorrow night, I say we get our schedules and relax a little with our evening.”

“Sounds good,” Mary agreed.

“Yeah, I’m down,” Vince said. “I’ll meet you guys there. I need to run a quick errand first.”

“We’ll try to survive without you,” Nick assured him.

\* \* \*

Michael Clark was halfway across campus, heading toward the nearest dining hall, when he realized he was being followed. He kept his head trained in the same direction and tried not to give any indications he was aware. There weren’t many people around – regular classes didn’t start until Monday this year, so he didn’t have to worry about any bystanders if things got violent. Not that he would have anyway. No, his only real concern was if things got wild and he used his powers he might get identified. That was still a big no-no, so he’d try to restrain himself.

Michael slowed his pace by a few steps, letting the muffled gait of his pursuer draw closer, then spun around on his heels with his fists up, ready to deal with the threat by any means necessary. What greeted him was a figure with familiar hair and a slightly startled expression on his face. Michael didn’t let his guard down one bit. If anything, he grew tenser.

“Trying to sneak up on me, huh? Can’t say I’m surprised,” Michael spat.

“I think I’ll gloss over the irony of that particular statement,” Vince said. “I’m not trying to sneak up on you or attack you.”

“Sure, then why are you following me?” Michael asked.

“Well, I needed to talk to you,” Vince explained.

“You’ve been following for a while just to talk.”

“I wasn’t really sure how to start things off,” Vince said. “So I kept trying to think of a good way, but stayed close so I could and then... I suppose you started things for me.”

“Uh huh,” Michael said skeptically. “Fine, then. I’ll play along: what did you want to talk about?”

“Two things, actually. First off, I wanted to know how you found out about us last year.”

“Lots of research and putting the pieces together.”

“No, that’s how you proved it to everyone else. I wanted to know what tipped you off in the first place.”

Michael stared at his opponent fiercely. There was nothing aggressive in his body language, nothing to suggest this request was coming with a threat of violence if not complied with. Still, Michael didn’t owe this freak any favors.

“There was always something off about you,” Michael lied. “I just trusted my gut and kept digging until I found the truth.”

Vince sighed. “If that’s what you want to stick with then I can’t force you to tell me. We will find out eventually. I’d just hoped you would have been a little more helpful.”

“Hope is a beautiful thing, you hang onto that,” Michael said. “What else did you want?”

“Oh, well, the other thing I wanted is to say ‘thank you’.”

Michael tilted his head in skepticism.

“No, I mean it. Not only for setting me free from living a lie, but for helping me see how wrong I was last year,” Vince said.

“What do you mean?”

“I kept thinking that by limiting my power intake I was keeping everyone else safe. I was so scared of losing control that I purposely kept myself as weak as possible. But if you hadn’t stirred up the whole campus, I doubt George and Persephone could have slipped off with our friends and in that whole fiasco I realized something important: I can’t keep anyone safe if I’m weak. I have to get past my fear of losing control and start using my power to its limit and then some. If I really want to keep everyone safe then I’ve got to be stronger than everyone and everything else,” Vince explained. “So, for that lesson, I sincerely do want to thank you.”

“You’re welcome,” Michael said with a sneer. “Let me know if there’s anything else you want me to teach you.”

“Oh, I don’t think there’s any need for that,” Vince replied. His voice was the same, as was his stance, but something seemed to shift to Michael. He couldn’t put his finger on why, however he was certain something about this situation had become vastly more dangerous.



“I took that lesson to heart, Michael, and I think you’ll find I’m now far less hesitant about how much power I keep held within me. I genuinely meant that thank you, and I do hope one day you and I can become mutually respectful peers, if not outright friends. That said, until you get past whatever issues you seem to have with me, you should stay away. From me, and especially from my friends.”

“Big talk from a freak,” Michael said. “I think someone needs to be reminded which of us always wins our fights.”

Michael took a step forward and readied himself to charge. Suddenly he felt his breath slip out of his chest as the air around him rippled with heat. In less than a second the temperature had leapt up by tens of degrees and it was only getting hotter. He tried to gulp down new air but it burned at his lungs and gave him little relief. He fell to a knee in hopes of seeking cooler air closer to the ground. Then, just as soon as it had started, it was over. The heat dissipated and Michael was able to take several ragged breaths to sooth his pounding heart.

“I’m not here to fight. I just wanted to ask you a question and say thanks,” Vince said calmly. “I don’t have interest in fighting you, Michael. I never did. The difference is that I’m not going to put up with your antics anymore either. Please keep that in mind next time you decide to ambush me, because I’m done pulling punches.”

Vince turned and headed off toward his dorm, leaving Michael still panting for air and fuming with rage.

## 11.

It was later than he expected when a series of sharp knocks rang against Nick's door. He glanced at the clock and saw the glowing digital numbers flashing nearly midnight. He supposed it was a Friday night, and Mary and Hershel would want to get some couple time in after all. Still, it was a good thing he was a night owl or else Nick might have been perturbed at the intrusion.

He opened the door to reveal Mary, dressed for the night in sweatpants and an oversized t-shirt, who walked briskly past him and plopped down in his desk chair.

"Can I help you?" Nick asked.

"You sure can," Mary replied. "We need to talk about the team."

"Wouldn't that require the rest of the aforementioned team to be present?"

"Don't be an ass. I trusted your judgment on picking Camille and Alex today. That doesn't mean I don't want to know why you thought they were the best choices," Mary said.

"Someone is feeling nosy."

"Someone is feeling responsible. I got selected as Captain, which means the hard choices fall on me to make. I think I've got a better chance of doing that if I have the best understanding of my team possible."

"Why, Ms. Smith, are you saying that I can offer insight even to a telepath?"

"I'm saying you're a better tactician and strategist than anyone else in our group. And yes, part of being a good leader is surrounding yourself with smart people and then actually listening to them," Mary shot back. "Now, can we please end this little dance? You knew I was coming over for this, and I knew that you knew, which you knew, and blah blah blah."

"I suppose that's fair," Nick said, sitting on the edge of his bed and facing Mary. "So you want to know why I picked Alex and Camille. Well, let's get the obvious out of the way first: Camille is the only healer in our class. Having her means that we are literally the lone team in any game that

can bring pieces back onto the board after they have been eliminated. That single fact would have made me pick her, but she actually brings more to the table than that. She's socially awkward enough to be accustomed to the ostracization that will accompany siding with us, and she's one of the few people whose loyalty we will never have to question."

"What makes you say that?" Mary asked.

"Because she's in love with Vince."

"How do you-"

"Oh, come on, it's not that hard. The girl never even glances at him unless she absolutely has to, and when she does it looks like she just swallowed a live chicken that's trying to work its way free. She blushes every time he's in vicinity of her, and she gave up being a number one draft pick to join us. Frankly, it's so obvious that really anyone could tell if they paid attention. Anyone other than Vince, I mean."

"I suppose so," Mary agreed. "I'm a little disappointed in myself for not knowing until today. I mean, I listened to her after we all huddled and... wow. I've never seen so much appreciation and dedication. I don't know what the whole story is, but Vince must have done something incredible to leave an impression like that on the girl."

"Though it pains me to sound so optimistic, that wouldn't be much a stretch to believe, given that it's Vince," Nick said begrudgingly.

"Why, Nick, it almost sounded like you were showing faith in your friend for a moment there," Mary teased.

"Moving on," Nick said. "Alex was chosen for similar reasons, personality-wise. He is accustomed to being an outcast and has a high level of loyalty to our group. That will keep him from buckling under the coming pressure."

"Yes, but the same could be said for Thomas, who would have brought abilities we didn't already possess as well," Mary pointed out.

"Thomas would have been good," Nick conceded. "However, the reason I chose Alex is precisely because we already have abilities similar to his. You see, you and he are the only people with any telepathic talents in the class, correct?"

"So far as I'm aware, yes."

“You are. Which means our team now has on it the only people capable of hearing other students’ thoughts. While that does give us duplication in some respects, it does something far more important. It robs our opponents of any mind-reading. We are the only team that doesn’t have to worry about our strategies and plans being overheard, and we are the only ones who can pluck those same ideas from the brain of our opponents.”

“Ohhhh,” Mary said, comprehension dawning. “So it wasn’t about having Alex as much as it was about taking him away from everyone else.”

“Exactly,” Nick said. “Whether the team matches are maze-style encounters like our midterms or just out and out brawls, the ability to know our opponents’ actions before they make them is invaluable. Plus, Alex isn’t entirely duplication. He can do some things you can’t.”

“Such as?”

“It’s commonly understood that telekinesis can’t stop energy, right?”

Mary nodded. “There isn’t enough mass for us to interact with.”

“You should talk to Vince sometime about his and Alex’s fight with Thomas. I think you’ll find Alex has his own potential uses beyond just a backup for you.”

“I’ll do that. So tell me something, o ye who commands we pawns. You saw the other team compositions while we were in the gym, what do you think our chances against them are?”

“Better with some than others. Shane’s team is combat heavy; I mean, he got Stella, Violet, and Thomas, so if we’re put in a pure fight against them we’ll be in trouble. Britney’s is the inverse, more stocked with unique technique users like Gilbert and Adam. They’d have the upper hand if we did games that didn’t require conflict. Chad’s team is the closest to ours. He chose a good mix of both combat- and technique-oriented students so that he’s got a viable game plan for any situation.”

“So we have the best shot against his team?” Mary asked.

“Oh no, the worst. He composed his in the same style as ours, but with much stronger people. Rich, Sasha, Selena, we are talking about some Supers that are not to be taken lightly,” Nick explained. “As it stands now, we’d have no chance of winning against his team.”

“Hmm. I suppose that only leaves us with one option,” Mary

surmised. “We have to get stronger.”

“Indeed we do,” Nick agreed. “Training starts tomorrow, so get some rest. I promise, it will challenge you in ways you never expected.”

Mary was tempted to peek into Nick’s mind and see just what he had in store, but she thought better of it. She had a feeling that whatever it was, hearing about it this late would not be conducive to a good night’s sleep.

## 12.

Nick flipped the cards onto his desk again, staring at the hand before him with a frown. There was no doubt about it: his assessments were spot on, but in a way he wished they weren't. He might have liked to take solace in ignorance, to quiet the machinations of his ever-ticking mind. Since that option was not presented to him, he instead looked at the other hands on the table. There were four of them, each different from the last. The arrangement would have seemed random to anyone else, which indeed was why Nick had chosen this medium for physical observation. The others didn't need to know what he knew, not yet anyway.

They needed to bond first, and bonding meant spending time together in high spirits. High spirits were best sustained when one believed they had a significant chance of victory. Nick would have to crush those hopes soon, because as it stood the hand before him was the weakest one on the table. That meant if they were hoping for a real shot at victory there was only one course for them: changing the cards.

Nick set down the remainder of the deck and checked the time. People would start arriving soon. He needed to get ready. If things went to plan, he could use tonight to get people bonded and to lay a bit of the groundwork they'd need for the tasks ahead. If they didn't... well, given the number of backups Nick had in mind, it would be quite extraordinary for things not to go according to at least one plan. He reached into his closet and pulled out a dark-colored button-down. He'd gotten most of the prep work done during the day; however, he still had a few tasks left.

\* \* \*

Camille stepped nervously into the Melbrook common room to find all the others already gathered. She hadn't been sure what Nick meant by "dress nice" so she'd changed outfits several times trying to strike the right chord. Initially she'd gone with a white dress that went to her calves, but she'd opted against it in case the night's activities required any extensive movement. Eventually she'd settled on a light green blouse and jeans. Looking about the room at the range of clothing, from Alice's pink dress to Alex's flip-flops, she decided she'd struck a good medium.

"And at last, we are all assembled," Nick declared, gesturing to the short girl's entrance.

“Sorry I’m late,” she said weakly.

“Don’t worry about it,” Mary said. “Alice only got out here around two minutes ago.”

“I had to find the right shoes,” Alice defended.

“How do you know which shoes are the right ones? You don’t know what we’re doing,” Mary pointed out.

“Thus I selected the ones that were utilitarian in function and adorable in looks,” Alice shot back. “On that note, what are we doing tonight? Now that Camille is here will you finally tell us?”

“I’d be happy to, once we arrive,” Nick replied with a smile. “For the trip we’ll need to split up into three vehicles. I’ll drive, Alice will drive, and I believe Alex has a car as well.”

“I’ve got a Focus that’s a few years old,” Alex confirmed.

“We’ll do our best not to hold that against you,” Nick said. “To the cars!”

“Don’t you need to tell the drivers where we are going?” Vince asked.

“Nope! Just follow my car!”

“This seems kind of weird, even for him,” Alice whispered to Mary as the group filtered out the front door.

“Leave it be, I’m sure he has something in mind,” Mary said.

Alice raised an eyebrow. “Did you peek?”

“No, but I mean, it’s Nick. For all his excessive eccentricity, he always has a goal behind the things he does.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Alice sighed. She wished Mary was a little less correct in that assessment.

After some quick debate, the cars were stocked with passengers. Alice, Mary, and Roy piled into Alice’s car. Camille joined Alex in his, leaving Vince and Nick to rely on the Volkswagen for transportation.

\* \* \*

The knock on Dean Blaine’s door was loud and pronounced. The educator glanced at one of the many monitors hooked up to the closed-circuit

camera system to see who his guest was. Despite the everyday appearance of the four-bedroom home a few blocks from campus, Dean Blaine's house was a fortress of security. Concealed cameras covered all areas of his perimeter, the charming bay windows housed glass of a thickness rated "rocket-resistant", and his doors and walls were all reinforced with sheets of steel in their centers. Some might have considered it a bit of overkill. Those people had never worked as Heroes. The ones who were lucky enough to retire had to take precautions to make sure they lived long enough to enjoy it.

In this instance, Dean Blaine had little to fear from his weekend caller. He unbolted the front door and swung it open, revealing Sean Pendleton dressed in a pair of slacks and a black silk shirt.

"I couldn't get you to dress this nicely for the first day of meeting students, but you'll do it to intrude on my time off?"

"Now don't be like that, Blaine," Sean said, a cheerful smile plastered to his face. "There was a time when we tore up the town on any given weekend."

"That time was long ago, and with a much larger group I might add. And you can call me Dean Blaine. You're an employee now, need I remind?"

"I am indeed, but we're off the clock," Sean pointed out. "Besides, I come bearing gifts." From behind his back Sean produced a small but very nice bottle of scotch.

"Dare I ask how you acquired it?"

"I did have a savings account with legitimate funds before my incarceration," Sean said. "So what do you say, shall we have a drink then perhaps go out on the town for old times' sake?"

"Are you really that bored?"

"Dreadfully so, I'm afraid," Sean lied. "There's little action to be found in this town when one is on the side of authority."

"Fine," Dean Blaine acquiesced. "You can come in for one glass of scotch. Just one."

"You haven't changed a bit, dear boy," Sean said, stepping into the tastefully decorated living room. "Still always willing to put yourself out to cheer up a friend."



Dean Blaine shut the door and bolted it behind Sean. He let the comment pass without objection, though he couldn't help noting just how wrong Sean was. Dean Blaine knew himself quite well, and he knew he had definitely changed in their time apart.

He just wished he knew if it was for the better or not.

### 13.

The bottle was nearly empty as Blaine topped off both their glasses. His head had a pleasant swim about it, not quite so much that his senses were yet on leave. It was more that they were on a coffee break: not immediately active but ready to spring at a moment's notice, if called. It was the stage of intoxication he liked best, and one he rarely went past.

"Scotch," Sean said, tasting the word as much as the drink. "This is one of those things you expect not to notice how much you miss in prison. Then you get out and it's like a shock to the system, you didn't even know how much you wanted some. That, by the way, is a crock of shit. I was keenly aware of how much I missed this and a thousand other little pleasantries from the outside world."

"And yet it took me ample convincing to get you to leave," Blaine pointed out.

"You'll forgive my hesitation. Our last encounter wasn't exactly one that captured the pinnacles of our friendship."

"Sean... well, I can't really say I'm sorry, given what you were doing. I still wish it hadn't had to be me that brought you in."

"I understand, Blaine. In the end it had to be someone from our class, and given all that's unfolded since then, perhaps I was lucky to be snared by Zero after all."

Blaine shook his head a little. "Of all the futures I imagined when we were enrolled here at Lander, I must say this wasn't one of them."

\* \* \*

"Open the door!" Sean yelled, his voice muffled by something. Blaine and Gerard both stood from the table, but Victor had already been up getting a drink, giving him the advantage of position. He flung open the flimsy apartment door to reveal Sean, arms loaded down with a case of beer and assorted snacks. He had a bag of chips in his teeth, which accounted for the distortion in his speech.

"About time," Victor thundered. No matter how often Blaine and Gerard tried to explain to him that they had neighbors who were partial to silence, the barrel-chested young man was never quite able to restrain himself

fully.

“Maybe if I’d had a little help I could have made better time,” Sean snapped, wobbling through the entrance under the burden of his load.

“Maybe if you were better at poker you wouldn’t have lost last week and been tasked with snack duty,” Victor fired back, one of his ham-sized hands delicately plucking a fresh beer from the case to join the one he’d already gotten from the fridge and drank halfway down. Blaine and Gerard got up to help Sean unload, a relatively quick process consisting of putting chips on the counter and beer in the fridge. With the food settled, they sat down at the small kitchen table and Gerard began to shuffle. His bony fingers were shockingly delicate and deft, rearranging the order of the cards with exemplary speed.

“What we need are fresh players,” Sean proposed, settling into his own seat and popping his weary back. “That way I’m not always getting my clock cleaned by you guys.”

“We’ve invited everyone in our class,” Blaine pointed out. “Then again, we’re seniors now, so the environment is leaning more toward outright competitive than friendly.”

“In fairness, that’s not true of everyone,” Gerard pointed out. “Phil and Joshua aren’t avoiding us out of malice; they simply prefer to spend their time training.”

“Not to mention Phil is such a Boy Scout he’d never play poker. And wherever Phil is, that’s where you’ll find Clarissa,” Victor added. He held himself back from the sigh that wanted to escape his lips. That girl was so breathtaking, yet all she ever seemed to do was follow after Phil like a puppy with an oblivious master.

“Casper comes to some of our other stuff,” Sean said.

“Yes, but he refuses to take part in anything involving gambling. The tenants of his faith label it a sin,” Gerard expanded.

“And of course Marianne has been dating that guy for the past couple of months,” Sean said.

“A Super like her with a human. Such a waste,” Victor said with a shake of his head.

“Love doesn’t draw distinctions between those with and without

abilities,” Gerard said, his quick hands now doling out the cards one by one. “Now, how about we cease lamenting those who aren’t present and focus on the game with those who are?”

“Fine, fine,” Sean said, looking at his hand. The game was five card draw, and it was not starting out well for him. “So, you guys nervous about the final exam in a few weeks?”

“Terrified,” Blaine said immediately.

“Hell, I didn’t mean you, Blaine. Of course you’re going to make the cut.”

“Nothing is certain in our world,” Gerard corrected him. “Though I agree that there is a very high likelihood my roommate will gain the title of Hero.”

“I’m definitely going to be one,” Victor declared loudly. “No matter what they throw at me, I can handle it.”

“Oh? So what’s the plan if they make you square off against Blaine, or Joshua, or Phil?” Sean asked.

“Obviously it’s a secret,” Victor replied. “I can’t just go telling you what my strategy is with Blaine right there.”

“I can leave the room if you like,” Blaine offered.

“No, no, that’s fine. I’ll just keep it to myself, thank you very much,” Victor said hastily.

Sean smiled. Despite his big talk and boisterous nature, Victor was actually a pretty solid guy to have on your team. He really hoped the lummoX made it through. As for his own chances at graduating, he evaluated them about half and half.

“For me I think it comes down to what the test is,” Sean speculated. “In the right environment I can be quite impressive. In the wrong one I can look useless.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. No one who looks useless makes it this far,” Blaine said. He set down two cards, which Gerard swept into a pile before doling out two fresh ones.

“Everything is relative,” Sean said. “Compared to some of the heavy hitters out in the world, all of us would look pretty weak.”

“Then let us be thankful none of them are enrolled at Lander,” Gerard replied, setting a small set of chips in the center. There were monetary values ascribed to the chips, just not nearly at the standard denominations. With a buy in of only five dollars, the game wouldn’t last too long without the ability to bet low values.

Victor raised by ten cents, Sean checked, and Blaine raised by another five cents. Each was so focused on the game laid out before them that they nearly jumped in surprise at the knock on the door. Blaine and Gerard exchanged curious glances. They weren’t expecting any other players to tonight’s game.

“Maybe someone decided to join us at the last minute?” Sean tossed out.

Blaine rose from his seat and crossed the short distance to the door. He pulled it open to reveal a pretty girl with wavy blonde hair.

“Hey, Blaine,” she said cheerfully. “My stupid brother forgot his wallet in my car after getting the groceries. I came to drop it off.”

Blaine stepped aside to allow entrance, giving the girl a greeting smile.

“Hey, Shelby,” Victor called.

“Good evening, Shelby,” Gerard greeted. “Would you like to join us?”

“No, thanks,” she said, making her way to Sean. “I just figured someone might need this when he loses again and has to pay up at the end of the night.” She held out a slim black piece of leather, which Sean accepted bashfully.

“Thanks, sis,” Sean said. “But I don’t expect to lose tonight; I’m feeling lucky.”

“Uh huh. I don’t need to see the future to know how bad you suck at poker,” Shelby said with a mischievous smile.

“I’m sure it helps,” Blaine said, pulling up his own chair. “Would you like a beer or a snack?”

“Thanks, but no thanks,” Shelby replied. “I need to hustle; I’ve got a date tonight.”

“Same guy?” Sean asked.

“Same guy,” Shelby confirmed.

“That’s four weekends in a row. Do I need to give this gentleman the standard ‘put the fear of big brother into him’ talk?” Sean asked.

Shelby laughed. “I appreciate it, but he’s one of Blake’s friends so he’s already been thoroughly threatened with fraternal retribution should he hurt me.”

“Long as the job gets done,” Sean said, adding another few chips to the pile.

“You guys have fun, and don’t cream my brother too bad,” Shelby said, showing herself out and shutting the door behind her.

“See, now I feel bad, because when we totally wreck you tonight it will feel like we’re going against your cute little sister,” Victor said.

“Don’t worry about it; regardless of what she says, tonight I’m feeling lucky,” Sean said proudly. “I’m going to win this game, then in a few weeks I’m going to ace the test and become one of the world’s greatest Heroes.”

“Nothing wrong with dreaming,” Gerard said. “In a perfect world we’d all make the cut and meet together decades from now to play a game of cards and talk about all the villains we’ve brought to justice.”

“Perfect world my ass,” Victor said. “That will definitely happen, just you watch and see.”

\* \* \*

The bottle was now empty, and the two lone figures sat in Blaine’s house, watching through the windows as the wind whipped at the trees.

## 14.

Roy leapt for the fence, his fingers taking grip and his strong arms pulling him to safety just in time. The mother elephant was very unhappy and was making her rage known. Keeping careful hold on the phone with his left hand, Roy pulled himself up with his right. Eventually he got his footing and began climbing the tall steel fence as the elephant rampaged beneath him. Nearby, Vince and Alex watched nervously as Roy moved. It was pretty obvious why he had to be the one in the picture after this ordeal, but Roy still felt a tad bitter. When this was all said and done, he and Nick were going to have a very long talk.

\* \* \*

Alice floated to the ground gently, Camille waving to her that the photo had been a success. She hurried over to the other two girls and tried to smooth her now wind-whipped hair.

“Okay, that takes care of Alice standing on a traffic light,” Mary said, dragging her pencil across the orange paper.

“How many left?” Camille asked.

“Six to go,” Mary replied. Alice checked her watch. That only left forty-five minutes until the deadline. They were really going to have to hurry.

“Let’s move then, what’s next?”

“We need Camille riding on top of a horse,” Mary said.

“Do we have any idea where to find a horse at eleven at night on a Friday?” Camille asked.

“No, but after tonight we will,” Alice said. They’d come this far, there was no freaking way they were going to give up.

\* \* \*

“So, here it is ladies and gentleman,” Nick had said several hours prior, producing two pieces of paper from his pocket. One was orange and the other blue.

“Are we doing arts and crafts?” Alice asked. She was confused and more than a little annoyed. He’d led them to a small parking lot some ways

into downtown. It appeared to be for a nail salon that was closed for the weekend. Lit only by a street light, Nick's grin was positively devilish as he addressed his teammates.

"Nope: photo scavenger hunt, of sorts," Nick replied. "On each page is a list of photos you need to take. There are requirements for specific people in some of them, so make sure you plan appropriately."

"How exactly is this team bonding?" Mary asked. "Fun, sure, in the right circumstances, but I'm not certain what the point here is."

"If it were obvious then you wouldn't need to do it to understand," Nick said. "Trust me, when this is all over you'll be a much more effective team."

"I guess we can give it a shot," Vince said. Even he was having trouble concealing his disinterest.

"I'd hope so, I mean, with what's on the line and all," Nick baited.

"What do you mean?" Alex bit.

"Didn't I mention? There's a prize if you manage to complete your lists by midnight. Since it has been brought to my attention that you philistines don't enjoy slasher cinema with the same gusto I possess, if you can bring me your pictures by midnight then I'll swear never to hijack our events into horror movie marathons again."

"Wait, seriously?" Alice said, light and hope sparkling into her eyes.

"I swear it on my love of sarcasm," Nick replied. "But if you fail, then we'll be spending tomorrow in a day-long fright flick fest."

"Seems like a gamble," Alex said. He was trying to play it cool but inside he was burning with desire to take the bet.

"Such is life," Nick replied. "I'm going to be at Toady's, the bar down the street. If you succeed, we spend the night relaxing in a nice lounge with the tab on me. If you fail then we go over the reasons why."

"I get it," Vince said. "This isn't about pictures, it's about seeing how we organize to accomplish a common goal."

"Always at the top of the class," Nick said. Of course, this wasn't nearly the extent of it, but Vince at least had the gist.



“Then I’m in,” Vince said.

“Me, too,” Alice agreed. The others signaled their affirmation and Nick handed out the papers. They were left to separate and distribute responsibility as desired. Once upon a time he would have had to give out cameras too. Thankfully the dawn of the cell phone age had rendered such additions unnecessary. He stepped into his car and left them to debate, the teams already coming together just the way he’d expected them to.

\* \* \*

Alex slid down from the piece of modern art carefully, still not certain who referred to a sheer vertical wall as art. He’d gotten his picture atop it, so whatever it was, it was crossed off the list. That was a good thing too, because time was quickly running out. The pictures weren’t terribly hard to get – well, except maybe the elephant one - but they had specific requirements and took time to drive to. A tickle in the back of his mind wanted to pay more attention to that fact, along with the requirements of people in pictures. It felt there was something there, something he should be paying attention to.

Instead he focused on getting down safely. Next up was a Vince picture then two more and they were home free.

\* \* \*

Nick sat comfortably as the soft music filtered down from the speakers. Toady’s had a pleasant atmosphere with gentle lighting and comfortable seating. It was trendy enough to have people but not so popular that it was swamped. He held down the large area with ease as he waited for his friends to arrive. A quick check of his watch told him they had fifteen minutes left until the deadline. Part of him almost felt bad for them, knowing there was no way they’d be done on time. It was necessary, though: failure led to insight, which led to growth. They needed to fail. Better it be at some stupid little contest than somewhere that mattered.

Besides, he had some choice films selected for tomorrow.

## 15.

When Vince, Alex, and Roy finally arrived at the lounge, they found the girls already sitting at Nick's side, a look of defeat on their pretty faces. Nick, on the other hand, looked like the cat that got the cream, drinking a soda and flashing them a winning grin as the three young men approached his section.

"I call shenanigans," Roy thundered, bounding ahead of the others. "There was no way we could have done all that in the time frame you gave us. The places were all over town."

"I hate to say it, but I agree," Alex said. "I think you set us up for failure on this one."

"That does sound like Nick," Alice mumbled under her breath.

"We only beat you guys here by a few minutes," Mary told them.

"Which was still a good half hour past the deadline," Nick pointed out, setting down his drink. "Now, let me address your concerns. Did I set you up to fail? Well, it depends on what you mean by that phrase."

"We're listening," Mary said.

"If you mean I did it knowing you would fail, then yes. If you mean it as I gave you a task that couldn't be accomplished, then no. What I gave you was doable, I just knew you all wouldn't be successful at accomplishing it."

"How could you know something like that?" Camille asked, her voice only a few degrees louder than the background music.

"Elementary, my dear healer," Nick told her. "I knew you'd go after this the same way most of you go after every problem: you'd pick a path and charge ahead blindly. At no point did it occur to you that there might be some strategy to implement in this particular task."

"Like what?"

"For starters? You could have mapped out your routes a bit. Nearly all of my tasks had specific geographical markers required. If you all had taken the time to lay out a map, like so-" Nick pulled a folded map from his pocket and set it on the table in front of him. He unfurled it, showing a variety of dots scattered across the town's surface. There were six different colors, each in

locations the group was now more familiar with. “-you could have easily seen the natural clusters and plotted a path that had you doing one task after another, cutting down on travel time drastically.”

Alex stared at the dots, piecing together who was what color from the spots he knew various pictures had been taken. Something was nagging at him, and now that there was time to think he let that nag mature into a full-grown thought.

“You’re lying,” Alex said. “Roy is red, Vince is blue, and I’m orange, right?”

“Correct,” Nick confirmed.

“Then there was no ideal route. No matter what we did we’d still have to cross town at least twice. That trip alone would have put us over the time,” Alex pointed out.

“Correct again,” Nick agreed. “Which brings me to my next point. You formed the wrong teams.”

“How?” Roy demanded. “You gave us the papers with our requirement. All the boys were on orange and the girls were on blue.”

“I did do that, but I never told you how to split up,” Nick pointed out. “You just accepted the format that was given to you without applying any thought of your own.”

“Shit,” Alex said, his face still peering at Nick’s map.

“What?” Mary asked.

“He’s right. If instead of the red dot Vince and I had been paired with the white one we could have easily planned a route with almost no backtracking,” Alex said, pointing to the map to illustrate.

“But then how would we have known what pictures to take? The other team would have had the paper you needed for at least one person’s pictures,” Alice said.

Vince shook his head. “We were using cell phone cameras with digital displays. It would have taken no time for us to photograph the other team’s sheet.”

“Right again,” Nick said. “I’m starting to think you folks are smarter than you look.”

“So what, if we’d done all this prep work we had no idea we needed, then we could have won the bet? That seems pretty convoluted,” Alice accused.

“Does it? Does creating a real life demonstration of your natural failings in an environment with low consequences seem convoluted? Perhaps you’re missing the point of this little display,” Nick said, rising from his seat. “I wanted you to see what you all lack, which is planning and critical thinking skills. At no point did any of you try a strategy even remotely outside the box. You ran forward recklessly, focused on just doing things faster rather than smarter. The reason you lost tonight isn’t because you weren’t intelligent enough to figure this out, it is because you simply aren’t used to doing things that way. But you need to be, because if our previous test showed us anything, it is that these exams won’t boil down to pure power. We’ll need strategy, too.”

“Isn’t that what we’ve got you for?” Vince asked.

“Yes, and at the same time no,” Nick replied. “I’ll explain more later on; right now let’s just relax a little. The game is over so we can sit back and shoot the shit for the remainder of the night.”

“Works for me,” Alice agreed.

“Then tomorrow will begin the slasher marathon to end all slasher marathons,” Nick finished.

“Wait, you’re really going to make us do that? I thought it was just a threat so we’d work harder,” Alex said.

“Oh no, I always honor my bets,” Nick informed him. “Besides, if there are no consequences to failure then the lessons just don’t take as well.”

Vince turned to Camille. “If you want to jump ship to another group, I bet there’s still time.”

His tone was light-hearted and clearly meant in jest. Still, Camille turned an analytical eye toward her new comrades. Half of them were glaring at the boy wearing sunglasses indoors, and most of the others were staring fiercely at a map in dim lighting. Tonight had been one of the oddest training exercises she’d ever participated in, but she had to admit it had been successful in driving home a point to everyone. Besides which, she’d actually kind of enjoyed herself in the hecticness of it all.

Camille gave Vince a small smile. “I think I’ll stick it out for a while longer.”

## 16.

Vince yawned broadly as he walked into the concrete-walled classroom. After Nick's movie marathon on Sunday he'd slept incredibly poorly. His dreams had been stuffed with monsters to the point where they slipped into the absurd. Case in point: one dream had him chased by a giant pumpkin wielding knives, while a later dream had him chased by a giant knife wielding pumpkins. The first had been scarier, yet curiously it was the second that jerked him from his slumber. He tried to shake off his weariness as he scanned for a seat; after all, this was the first day of his real classes. He wanted to be alert.

The classroom was more a circle of wooden benches than a lecture hall, all wrapping around a focal point where Professor Fletcher stood patiently. To be honest, Vince was more surprised there was any seating at all in a course on close combat; he'd expected more circles and days duking it out with fellow combatants. Still, after what he'd seen Professor Fletcher do, Vince wasn't going to question his methods. Any man with that much skill was worth listening to.

Other students began filtering into the room one by one. Thomas took a seat next to Vince, and they were soon joined by Stella and Violet. Chad and Shane entered a few minutes later, followed by Michael close at their heels. Sasha walked in with Julia and purposely passed by Vince without even a passing glance. Jill, at least, gave him a supportive smile before joining her suite mates when she walked in. Roy ambled in near the beginning of class and plopped down in the closest space he could find. One of the last people to enter was the most surprising to Vince.

"Camille? What are you doing here?"

"They assigned me," Camille said, glancing around the room nervously as she stepped farther from the doorway. Everyone seemed so much bigger than she. Bigger and stronger.

"That can't be right, you're a healer," Vince said worriedly. "Let's go talk to the professor and see-"

"It isn't a mistake," Stella interrupted. She glanced at her diminutive friend and raised an eyebrow. Camille gave her head the barest of shakes and Stella looked back at Vince. "Trust me, the girl belongs here."

“Are you sure?” Vince’s question was addressed at Camille, not Stella. No matter what anyone said, if his teammate didn’t feel she was up to the task, he wasn’t going to let her get hurt.

“I’ll be fine,” Camille assured him. She sat down on his other free side, and the remainder of the stragglers came into the room and plopped down, prompting Professor Fletcher to begin his first class.

“Good morning,” Professor Fletcher said to his bright-eyed students. His stunt on Thursday had been a bit heavy-handed, but the results couldn’t be argued with. He’d won their respect if not their admiration, and they were hanging on every word he said. Professor Fletcher pitied educators who didn’t have overwhelming brute force as a teaching tool.

“Let’s start with a little background. How many of you have been training in any form of martial combat for more than the past year?” Professor Fletcher asked.

Most of the hands in the room went up.

“Good, more than five years?”

A multitude went down, and Vince was a little surprised to see the slender arm next to him remain in the air. Camille did her best to look nonplussed.

“Better than I expected. Ten years?”

Nearly all the hands went down, only Vince’s, Shane’s, Michael’s, Roy’s, and Chad’s remained airborne.

“Nice. Any of you over-achievers got fifteen under your belt?”

Chad and Shane were now the only ones with their hands aloft.

“Okay then, for anyone without at least five years of training, we’re going to treat you like newbies,” Professor Fletcher said firmly. “That means we’ll be having one on ones to see the way you move and selecting the martial art that is best suited to your natural talents. Anyone who has five but less than ten, we’re going to stick with what you know. No sense in trying to break habits and reactions that are already ingrained. Those of you with ten years and up, congratulations. You just became teachers.”

“Say what?” Shane said in surprise.

“You heard me. You got your fill of pounding each other pointlessly

last year, though there will be plenty more of that to come. But people with your level of experience need to be teaching as well as training to advance. I can't be the first one to tell you this."

"It is a commonly accepted practice," Chad agreed. Shane did his best not to look abashed at having been ignorant of what was evidently public knowledge.

"Don't worry, I'm going to train you as well," Professor Fletcher assured him. "You'll just also be responsible for helping the newbies improve in whatever art they undertake."

"What if they choose one we don't know shit about?" Roy queried.

"Then hand off to someone who does. Or to me. You're not personal trainers, you're just there to answer basic questions and give feedback. It's not like the premise really varies that much. Hit the other guy and don't let him hit you. The rest is details," Professor Fletcher said. "Important details, but details all the same."

"Still feels like a waste of time," Roy grumbled.

"Tell you what, kid, the day you can beat me is the day you no longer have to listen to my methods," Professor Fletcher offered. "And that goes for all of you. When you're stronger than I am, then you become the teacher."

Chad mulled the idea over briefly. He couldn't beat the professor, not as he was now. But the fight hadn't been a complete loss for him. He'd been able to observe the older man's movements and techniques to some extent. He couldn't beat the professor yet; however, eventually that would change. It had to. Chad was aiming for a space at the very top of the mountain, a place of unassailable power.

That meant, sooner or later, Chad would have to surpass everyone, even the people teaching him. Even the friends sitting next to him. Even the Heroes out in the world already. Chad was going to pick up the name that the rest of the world seemed content to tread on and he was going to carry it all the way to the top. He wouldn't stop until he succeeded. No matter what.



## 17.

The Subtlety class was smaller than Close Combat, and had actual desks rather than a mere smattering of benches. Of course, there were only four students able to discern those differences, as very few had been selected for both courses. Julia and Sasha were both such rare cases, walking into the room and noticing they were among the last to arrive. They recognized Gilbert and Hector, both still softly simmering in sweat from the Close Combat class, lounging near the back. Sasha scanned the room further, noticing Will and on impulse turning to join him. That's when she noticed who he was already sitting with.

Sasha barely repressed a sneer as she altered her direction instantly. She understood that Will was somewhat insecure about the viability of his ability taking him all the way to Hero levels; Jill had confided that much in her during their first year as suite mates. Still, that didn't fully excuse his continued association with those freaks from Melbrook. It was bad enough she had to deal with Vince in her first class, now she was discovering that this one would be shared with the sunglasses-wearing weirdo and the buxom bitch. If some part of Sasha remembered that only four months ago she'd counted both of those two as friends, it kept itself silent. That is not to say it allowed itself to be extinguished, merely that it recognized the fact that biding one's time is a classic, and often beneficial, strategy.

"Good morning, class," Professor Pendleton greeted them. "I'm glad to see you all found the classroom today. I hope you have the same luck tomorrow." With that, he stood from the desk he had been nimbly perched and began handing out syllabi. The first hands went up before he'd even gotten halfway around the room. He dutifully ignored them, finishing the process and sitting back down at his desk.

"I can see you already have questions, but let's hold those for the moment, shall we? Instead, I'd like us to read through the syllabus. Who would like to start?"

Alice was slow in lowering her hand, still not quite ready to accept that she wouldn't get to query the strange professor for answers, so hers was the highest when he asked for volunteers.

"Thank you, Ms. Adair. Please start us off. Read the first paragraph."

“Um, I’m not sure it’s really a paragraph. I mean, it’s just one line,” Alice said uncertainly.

“Less lip and more reading, Ms. Adair,” Professor Pendleton replied swiftly. Alice felt her cheeks flush for a moment then turned her eyes to the page.

“Lesson One: Lie,” Alice recited dutifully.

“Adequate,” Professor Pendleton said. “Next part, how about Mr. Reid?”

“Lesson Two: Sneak,” Gilbert said, not bothering to question the curious nature of this process.

“Much better,” Professor Pendleton praised. “How about Mr. Weaver goes next?”

“Lesson Three: Cheat,” Rich snapped off automatically.

“And for the finale, I think it should go to Mr. Campbell,” Professor Pendleton instructed.

“Lesson Four: Think,” Nick said, eyeing the strange lanky man at the front of the class with something bordering on respect. He had an inkling where this was going and might have actually felt a twinge of excitement deep down in his gut.

“Lie, Sneak, Cheat, and Think,” Professor Pendleton repeated. “These are the tenants of a Hero who specializes in Subtlety. Very few of us are the physically powerful types. Those of you enrolled in combat classes will likely find yourself losing this course next year. We give you the opportunity, however, because one never really knows where the seed of true talent may have been planted.”

Professor Pendleton stood from his desk once more and stepped around to the front in a short series of long-legged movements.

“Now, before we go any further, there is something you all need to know. Subtlety is considered the grey line between Hero and criminal, and those who graduate with it as their major are seen as high-risk tightrope walkers along this metaphorical division. More of us turn to crime than any other specialty. There are a multitude of theories why that is the case, but at the end of the day the blame must be laid at least partially at the foot of the nature of our job. You see, those who master Subtlety do not bask in the

sunlight of public acclaim and moral purity. Rather, we are the ones who must outthink, outmaneuver, and out-plan our enemies. We are the ones who steal into a South American drug compound to retrieve data on the giant robot someone built. We are the ones who seduce and con friends of criminals to learn where they are and what weaknesses they have. We dirty our hands with the jobs that must be done but that no person with a sound moral compass would want. Because we can. We are smart enough, bold enough, and yes, grey enough, to handle the lurking and conniving. It is a thankless job, save only for others of your craft who appreciate the work you put in."

"Then why would anyone want to do it?" Will asked, the words popping out before his sense of logic could stop him.

"Because someone has to. Without those stolen plans, without that insider information, without a weakness to exploit, people are going to get hurt. Possibly die. Not just citizens either, but fellow Heroes. As I said, most of you with combat options will leave this class behind at the year's end. The reason is that you will have options outside of this path, and who can blame you for taking them? We are the fewest of any Hero type. We are also some of the most valuable," Professor Pendleton explained.

Will nodded his understanding and fell silent. He felt a stirring in himself, a stirring that was echoed in the bodies of several others around him. This was an avenue he'd never known about before, one he'd never suspected existed. This was one where wiles and wit were prized over bulk and biceps. This relied on quick thought and fluid morals. This was one he might actually be able to do.

"Now that I've hopefully turned most of you off to the profession as a whole, let me elaborate on the syllabus," Professor Pendleton continued. "We are going to learn the hallmarks of the field through the year, piece by piece. Make no mistake, the most important part is lesson four. That one we will be doing constantly. To that effect, our classroom will be a floating one. Some days I'll tell you where to meet next time. Other days I will give you a riddle, or a puzzle with the location concealed within. If you can't solve it, you miss the class. As you can infer, missing too much class doesn't reflect well on you when the year-end review comes around. With that said, I'd like you all to flip your syllabus onto its back."

The students complied, revealing a strange diagram with numbers dotting the edges and something that seemed like a maze in the center, with entrances jutting from each digit.

“That will tell you where to meet for the rest of this week,” Professor Pendleton said, giving what he felt was an adequate explanation. Still he decided to toss in some encouragement as well.

“Good luck.”

## 18.

Mary fidgeted nervously as she waited in the empty room. While all the rooms underground in Lander had concrete walls and a Spartan feel, the thick metal door and lack of any décor left no doubt that this was a space used for battle. She wondered why she was the only one here. She'd heard Professor Stone give her the instruction to come to this room after class, but only because she'd been listening to the older woman's thoughts. In the rest of the Focus, classroom the only other person who might have picked up the message was Alex and the Professor had been adamant that she not discuss her hearings with anyone else.

Mary knew she was being a bit paranoid, but given the events at the end of last year she felt that, if nothing else, it was prudent to show some caution. So before coming, she had let her friends know who she'd be meeting with and in what room. She'd also had them pass word to Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport. She'd felt a bit silly doing so - after all, this was probably nothing more than a quick teacher-meeting over something she needed to know. Still, she'd held out hope that someone else from the Focus class would be here, that Professor Stone had communicated with all of them in some way to send the message.

The older woman stepped gingerly in the door and extinguished any hope Mary was still holding onto that this might be a communal meeting.

"Good afternoon," Professor Stone greeted cordially. "How were the rest of your classes?"

"Ranged Combat was enjoyable," Mary replied. "Control was somewhat tedious."

"Give it time, I'm sure Professor Hill will challenge you soon," Professor Stone assured her. "Of course, eventually someone with your talents will find your specialty in Focus. That much is certain."

"Is it now?"

"Without question," Professor Stone reiterated. "Control is a useful course for anyone who moves the world around them in that it forces one to elevate their geospatial thinking and their awareness of the objects surrounding them. Control, however, is ultimately the manipulation of outer forces upon outer forces. That is a poor fit for those like you, Mary, because

your skill is inwardly oriented. Thus, you will find the most benefit in Focus.”

“Good to know. Is that why you asked me here?”

Professor Stone laughed, a soft tinkling sound that dried prematurely in her throat. She stepped further into the room, walking gingerly across the hard floor. “Don’t be ridiculous. I don’t waste my time telling students what should be obvious. No, I called you here because while Fletcher has a crude sensibility to him, the man’s tactics do present a certain amount of efficiency.”

“I see,” Mary said, her foot stepping back ever so slightly.

“Relax, little one, I don’t wish to harm you. It is simply that I didn’t get to test you last year, so I don’t know nearly enough about your limits to teach you effectively,” Professor Stone explained. “This is an evaluation, nothing more.”

“Ah,” Mary said, a trickle of relief seeping through her bones. “I suppose that makes sense.”

“A benefit of the truth: it holds together effortlessly,” Professor Stone said with a smile. The metal door to her left slammed shut forcefully, and across the room Mary could hear a locking mechanism click into place.

“I thought this was just an evaluation.”

“It is, but we take safety very seriously here in the Hero Certification Program,” Professor Stone said.

“How does locking us in make us safer?”

“It wasn’t our safety I had in mind,” Professor Stone informed her. “I’ve seen your fights and read your file. A girl with your talents will likely cause significant collateral damage before she reaches her own threshold.”

Mary gave the elderly woman a half-smile. “Not to mention the amount of power necessary to bring me there.”

Professor Stone returned the cheerful grin. “Yes, that, too.”

\* \* \*

Chad was in the gym doing a bench press when he heard a distant rumbling through the walls. Briefly, he wondered if it was thunder. After a moment’s pause, he realized any thunder strong enough to be heard all the way down here would leave the topside of Lander in splinters and destruction.

He considered investigating, then shrugged it off and finished his set of reps. Whatever it was, it probably didn't concern him.

\* \* \*

"Very impressive," Professor Stone said, stepping over the newly-formed rubble at her feet. "You can pack a lot of wallop in your attacks."

"I've been told I'm strong for my age," Mary said graciously.

"Don't be ridiculous: you're strong, period. Age has nothing to do with it." Professor Stone reached down and selected one of the biggest hunks of concrete, plucking it from the ground with a frail arm that couldn't have budged the miniature boulder without mental assistance. "Of course, raw blasting force is only one aspect of our abilities. There are other things, too. Things like sustained effort."

Professor Stone tossed the concrete in the air and it zoomed toward Mary. Mary took hold of it when it was a little over halfway to her, slowing its movement only to discover that something was still pushing it forward.

"Think of it as an inverted tug of war," Professor Stone explained. "We both push it toward one another until it reaches someone."

Mary understood and ratcheted up her effort level. The concrete moved back to the middle of the space between the two women where it stopped abruptly. Mary tried to push it further, but Professor Stone seemed to be able to match her perfectly, increasing power when she increased, and dropping when Mary faltered. Mary adjusted her foot positioning for comfort. If the old lady wanted to make it an endurance contest that was fine by her. She'd spent the first seventeen years of her life in constant mental alert to deal with the voices splashing through her mind. Mary could hold up a rock for days if she had to.

"You really could, too. This is almost effortless for you," Professor Stone complemented.

Mary blinked. It hadn't occurred to her the professor might be reading her own mind.

"Of course not; you're accustomed to being the only telepath at the party," Professor Stone said. "That's why you're so prideful and careless."

"Beg pardon?"

“You’re prideful. Despite what has happened, you still have a disproportionate sense of your abilities. Right now, you really think you can best one of your teachers in their field of specialty. Did it perhaps occur to you that George and Professor Fletcher aren’t flukes? That all of us are quite adept with our skills?”

“I just-”

“And as for careless, well, coming here alone in the first place was rather stupid of you. I know you told people, but by the time they knew you were gone you could already have been beyond retrieving. No, you showed up because at the end of the day, you believe that the only reason you were taken last time is because you were caught unaware. You think that if you’re cognizant, you can handle yourself in any situation.”

“I didn’t-”

“No, of course you didn’t. Well, let me lay it out for you, young lady. You are one of the strongest advanced minds I’ve ever encountered. That said, if I’d come down here to do you harm, you would already be unconscious. You need to start being cautious, you need to start watching yourself, and most importantly, you need to realize that ‘one of the strongest’ is not the same thing as ‘the strongest’.”

Mary felt the concrete tear through her own force as it sailed toward her small body. She tried to press back, but she couldn’t do more than slightly slow it down. A few feet before impact, the giant piece shattered and sent a spray of concrete shards around her. They tore against her arms and legs, but not one piece touched her torso.

Mary realized that at some point she’d closed her eyes. She slowly peeled them open to reveal Professor Stone slowly making her way toward the door, which was now open.

“I look forward to teaching you, Mary. You’ve got a lot of potential. Go see a healer before you head above ground.”

Mary glanced down and realized she had dozens of small cuts along her appendages, each one about the same length and depth. Only then did she understand what the professor had really done.

“Every piece... you were controlling every piece after it broke, all of them simultaneously,” Mary said, her shaky voice betraying the shock in her words.



Professor Stone didn't bother stopping or turning around. She'd seen how far the girl could go, and seen where she was weakest. All that remained now was to see if she had the determination to take her talents to the next level.

## 19.

Camille was happy to walk into her first class of the afternoon wearing regular clothes instead of her HCP uniform. As much as Lander underground was relaxing, in that everyone knew what she was and there was no pretense, it was also such a cloistered community that slipping into the background became nearly impossible. Camille had spent years steeling her nerves to be able to fight when the situation demanded it, but in her day-to-day life she was still much happier as the small girl who few people noticed. Not to mention that up here she was enrolled with the full Lander student populace, making her chances of running into Vince significantly lower.

It wasn't that she didn't like being around her silver-haired teammate; it was that she liked it far too much and was awful at hiding her feelings. Every time she flushed, every time she got all nervous and bumbly, she was sure it would be the time Vince would finally notice those things only happened around him. Mercifully, that hadn't happened yet; however, Camille wasn't one to push her luck. If she was going to help him, she needed to be near him, and there was surely no way to drive him off faster than revealing she cared for him as more than a friend.

Camille ascended the steps of the lecture hall, so absorbed in her thoughts that she nearly jumped a foot in the air when a well-manicured hand snaked out from an aisle and grabbed her arm.

"Gah!"

"Whoa, relax," Alice assured her. "I was calling your name, didn't you hear me?"

"Oh, I, uh, I guess not," Camille stammered out as her heart thundered in her chest.

"Sorry about that," Alice apologized. "I just wanted to get your attention before you went past. There are plenty of seats by me."

"Right, of course," Camille said as the adrenaline exited her system. She entered the row Alice was perched in and took a seat to her left. It wasn't exactly the anonymous background she'd craved, but at least it wasn't Vince. "So, how was your first day? I haven't seen you since our... since Professor Baker's class."

“It was okay,” Alice replied. “I think Professor Pendleton’s will be my worst. I mean, I’m not really good at any of them, but at least the others have outlined syllabi and stationary classrooms.”

“Yeah, I’ve heard that is one of the tougher subjects to excel in,” Camille replied.

“No worries there. I’m pretty sure he expects most of us to fail out of it by year’s end, which is fine by me. The hard part will be deciding which of the other two I want to try and squeak by in.”

“I’m sure it isn’t that bad. I mean, you made it to year two, after all.”

Alice sighed. “I did, but I’m still not sure if I would have if I’d gone through the normal channels.” Alice paused for a moment and seemed to steady herself mentally. “I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to be such a bummer. I guess all the stress of things is already getting to me.”

“It’s a problem I certainly understand,” Camille assured her.

“You know what the biggest issue is? It’s been all work since we got here. Even last weekend was a training exercise. I think we need to take a night off, just do activities that have nothing to do with... well, you know.” Alice had almost said ‘HCP’ out loud, a slip that easily would have ended all of her worries about it if she’d been overheard.

“That sounds nice,” Camille said, her tone as noncommittal as she could manage. She didn’t have the heart to tell Alice that any night spent around Vince wasn’t going to reduce her stress level, even if the activities were relaxing.

“Oh! I’ve got it,” Alice said, a spark of excitement lighting in her bright blue eyes. “Let’s do a girls’ night this Friday. Just me, you, Mary, and maybe some of the others. No training, no shop talk, we’ll even skip our afternoon classes and go do a mani/pedi treatment.”

“I’m not so sure that’s a good idea,” Camille objected.

“Oh, don’t worry, it’s the first week of classes, what’s the most we could miss? And I know a perfect little place near the ocean. I’ll make us reservations as soon as class is over.”

“I should really check my calendar,” Camille tried again.

“That’s a good idea; if you don’t have a class that runs too late in the

morning we can get lunch, too. We can practically make a whole day of it!”

Camille took a deep breath and tried to think of another excuse to throw up. Unfortunately she was learning the hard lesson that Mary had been privy to last year. Alice may not have much in the way of special abilities, but once her mind was set on something, one would have better luck changing the course of a river.

“Sounds... fun,” Camille conceded. It wouldn’t be that bad. It was just the girls after all, and they were going to be teammates now so a little bonding was in order.

“It will be, just wait, by the time Saturday rolls around we won’t have a care left in the world.”

“Except for the coming week, and the one after that, and the one after that, et cetera,” Camille pointed out.

“Well, yes, but you can’t let all of that snow pile on you. Or, if you must, you have to at least put it aside for our days off,” Alice replied.

“Days? As in multiple?”

“Of course, we’ll need more than just this over the coming year. Don’t worry; they won’t all be girls only. I just don’t want Nick to hijack our relaxation plans into some sort of ridiculous shenanigans.”

“He does that often, huh?”

“Ugh, more than you would believe. You’ll see for yourself soon, the boy is absolutely insufferable.”

Camille didn’t have a chance to reply because the professor stepped up to address the class, but even if he hadn’t she wouldn’t have known what to say next. She certainly couldn’t say what she was thinking, which was that for a girl who slandered Nick so readily, Alice seemed to light up noticeably when she talked about him.

That would be inappropriate, not to mention that Camille was the last person who ought to call someone out over conflicting feelings.

## 20.

Julia was halfway to her dorm when the tall, muscular figure fell into step beside her. She could smell him almost immediately, no frilly body wash or sickly sweet cologne; his was the smell of freshly scrubbed hard work. It set her teeth on edge before she ever turned to face him. Julia had managed a fling or two over the summer, but nothing that put her through the metaphorical (and one time literal) wall like he could.

“Afternoon, pretty lady,” Roy greeted, an easygoing smile stretched out amidst the afternoon stubble on his face.

Julia’s tongue nearly betrayed her, smashing against her teeth to usher a familiar greeting, a bubbly laugh, or just an immediate invitation to the nearest secluded place she could find. Her brain prevailed, clamping down on the friendly muscle and issuing new orders, ones that were not optional to comply with.

“Get lost, freak,” Julia spat, her libido raging internally.

“Now, that doesn’t seem like a neighborly greeting,” Roy replied, his grin unfaltered. “Sure you wouldn’t like to try again?”

“Fuck off.” Julia quickened her step, determined to make the travel run out before her self control did. She hated herself for even feeling the temptation. Yes, she’d enjoyed her time with Roy, and yes, they’d had tons of fun together, and sure, she might have developed some feelings for him over the past year. But none of that mattered. She couldn’t be the girl rolling around with a Powered. What would the other students say? Or, heaven forbid, what if her parents ever found out? No, she had to be done with Roy Daniels. Done with his stupid muscles, done with his handsome face, done with the way he bit her gently at the crux of her collarbone while his strong hand wrapped around the small of back and he... Julia refocused herself and increased her gait even more.

“You sure about this?” Roy asked as Julia’s walk began to verge on sprinting. No, she wasn’t, and she desperately wanted to turn around and pretend it had all been a joke. She plowed forward instead. Soon she’d be away from him and the frustration she was feeling would be nothing more than a barbed memory that time and forgetfulness would smooth until it was bearable. Somewhere deep down, a part of Julia recognized that it wasn’t just

her sexual desires railing at her for this choice, but a part buried under so much fear that its voice had no hope of rising to audibility.

Roy watched the blonde hustle toward her dorm and ceased his own walk. He'd suspected such a greeting when she refused to make eye contact with him in their classes, but he'd been hopeful a little personal attention would change her mind. It looked like he was wrong. Such a shame; Julia really had been one of Roy's favorites, holding his attention for over a year. A normal man might have taken such a dismissal by a girl so formerly enraptured with him as a blow to the ego.

With a swift turn, Roy headed back toward his own dorm, jogging ahead slightly to chat with a pair of coeds who weren't a part of the HCP. Roy Daniels was not a normal man, and he had no intention of letting one chick get him down. Roy might be a freak underground, but up on the surface he still considered himself the big dog on campus.

\* \* \*

"You're still stressed," Alex accused. He and Selena were sitting in her room, dining on a pizza. Selena sighed and set her third slice back in the box. If she was going to take the calories from it she was sure as hell going to enjoy it, and it seemed that meant talking things out first.

"Yeah, Alex, I am. My boyfriend sided with the school's collection of weirdoes in front of everyone. Can you see how that might be a little awkward for me?"

"We talked about this," Alex defended. "They're my friends and they're good people. Who they used to be shouldn't matter."

"Shouldn't is the keyword there," Selena replied. "A lot of things shouldn't matter. It shouldn't matter that my dad's skin is caramel-colored instead of ivory, yet he still gets passed over for a promotion every year. Just because something shouldn't matter doesn't mean it won't."

"So that makes it all right? To treat them differently because of how they were born?"

"No, of course it doesn't, but... Alex, I told you at the beginning of the year that I supported you sticking with them. I still do. But let's not pretend that it's some effortless choice without consequences. There is going to be blowback from taking their side, on you for doing it and on me for staying with you."

“So you think it was a mistake,” Alex said, half question and half accusation.

“No, not at all. I’m not saying the repercussions should change your mind; I’m just saying we shouldn’t pretend they aren’t there. So, yes, I’m stressed, because some people I counted as friends were assholes to me today. It’s going to happen, and probably more often than less. I’m okay with it.” Selene leaned across the cardboard container and kissed Alex gently, ending with a second light smooch on the corner of his mouth.

“You made your choice and I made mine. Just don’t call me out on the stuff I’m trying to downplay. Pretend you’re not telepathic every once and a while,” Selena said softly.

“That should be easy enough,” Alex agreed. “After all, I’m not a telepath.”

“Yeah, yeah, yeah,” Selena said, kissing him once more for good measure. That accomplished, she turned her attention back to the greasy, cheese-covered, fat-laden pizza slice calling up at her from the box below. She was going to have to run an extra half-hour tomorrow not to feel guilty about this. Her teeth tore through the first melty bite and flavor flooded her mouth.

Totally worth it.

## 21.

Nick had solved the puzzle from Subtlety before his first afternoon class was done. It wasn't all that hard, provided one had a basic level of pattern recognition and a head for numbers. No, the interesting part had been the second layer of it, barely noticeable unless you were looking for it, where a number equivalency substitution spelled out a separate code from the location-based one. This bit of information instructed the deciphering student to show up in a separate room twenty minutes prior to the start of class. It was clearly meant only for the overachievers to find, a test within a test to see who had the goods and who had the greats.

Nick felt his interest in Professor Pendleton rising even as he debated whether or not he should show up. It would mark him as intelligent and capable, two descriptors he worked adamantly to keep away from his character, but at the same time, it seemed Subtlety was his best bet for surviving into the next year. He was skilled at Ranged Combat, of course, and Weapons had gone well, however he'd easily been outstripped by those with abilities more rooted in the physical world. No, if he was going to make it past this year's cuts it would have to be in Subtlety, and he did want to get as much training as possible before the descent of the proverbial axe. Still, it compromised the uselessness that he worked so hard to convey to the others, and while his secret might be blown to his own team, it was still an element of surprise he could utilize against others in the competitions.

The risk-to-reward ratio was high, but Nicholas Campbell wasn't feared at every poker table in Las Vegas because he lacked the ability to make the hard choices. That thought put a smile on his face as a new plan coalesced in his mind. He didn't really have to make a choice. All he had to do was outfox Professor Pendleton at his own game. That seemed a far more fitting way to demonstrate his skill in the course anyway.

Mind at ease, Nick went about working out the logistics for his plan. He only had the morning to act, but given the general disarray of such a period, he was confident he could pull it off with relative simplicity. He didn't notice it, but he wore a grin as he worked. For the first time since he arrived at Lander, Nick wasn't just running a con or sneaking by: he was issuing a challenge. The prospect of a genuine opponent couldn't help but excite him.

\* \* \*



Professor Pendleton opened the door to the classroom to find it jammed full of students. He'd secured this room, anticipating a three- or four-person maximum attendance. The code he'd buried in the back of the syllabus wasn't exactly government-level encryption, but for sophomore students not even looking for it, only the most adept minds would even be alerted. That said, the moment he heard the buzz of noise it was evident something had gone horribly wrong.

The ruckus subsided as soon as Professor Pendleton's lean body stalked through the door. He surveyed the faces before him and confirmed, to his horror, that everyone enrolled in his course was here. He took a deep breath and analyzed the situation calmly. There was no way all of them successfully decoded the message of the early meeting. That left the next logical explanation.

"Perhaps I failed to properly explain," Professor Pendleton began, his voice even only thanks to his remarkable self-control. "The point of these exercises is to develop your own minds and skills. To that effect, collusion is greatly looked down upon in this class. Now, I'm sure the few of you who cracked the code only wanted to help a person or two each, to make your friends stand out, but as you can see, this is what happens when such behavior is indulged."

"Um, what are you talking about, professor?" Alice asked uncertainly. She was seated at the front of the room, hand eagerly raised even to convey this informal query.

"The hidden message in yesterday's puzzle that was clearly disseminated too freely," Professor Pendleton replied.

"What message?"

"The one that told you to come here."

"You mean the note?" Alice reached into her pocket and produced a folded piece of computer paper. Professor Pendleton snatched it from her hand, unfolded and began scanning through its contents.

"We all found them in our bags and uniform pockets this morning," Alice added helpfully.

Professor Pendleton heard but didn't acknowledge her; he was too absorbed in analyzing the document before him. It claimed to be a note from him, instructing the students to meet in this room at this time to discuss key

changes to the syllabus. It hadn't been signed, but of course the students would believe documents snuck onto their person could only have been accomplished by the teacher of the Subtlety class. There was nothing unique about the ink or paper. If he had to guess, it was likely the same used in the library above-ground. Someone had been thorough and thoughtful.

Professor Pendleton refolded the note and handed it back to Alice. He might not know who the culprit was, but he was able to recognize a shot across the bow. Someone was calling him out. He suppressed a smirk that tried to manifest itself at the thought that there might actually be some talent in his group after all.

"Everyone get to the classroom," Professor Pendleton instructed them. "I'd try to split you up so only the ones who solved the puzzle could find it, however, at this point I don't care. Just go. I'll be in shortly."

"What about the syllabus changes?" Alice asked.

"You found a mysterious note on your person and blindly trusted that it was from who it indicated," Professor Pendleton said. "That is expertly idiotic, and the only reason I'm not dropping down on all of you like a hammer is because I don't have any way to truthfully delineate who came here on their own and who only came because of the note. That said, Miss Adair, if you insist on asking such a relentlessly stupid question as to why I'm throwing you all out, after being clearly surprised by a note that I supposedly wrote, then maybe your day would best be spent focusing on one of the classes you have a better chance of still being enrolled in come next year."

"I... I'm sorry," Alice said softly, ducking her head down and all but bounding out of the classroom. The others followed at a respectful distance, none of them daring to pipe up after his unloading on the tall blonde girl.

As they filed out, Professor Pendleton reflected that he might have been harsher than intended. Still, the message was an important one. This might not be as physically-oriented of a major as the others, but it still demanded the same levels of excellence. Failing to analyze a situation or piece together details, even only once, could have just as disastrous consequences as failing to stop a speeding bus or catch a falling plane.

Better those who couldn't cut it turn their eyes elsewhere sooner rather than later. It seemed that wasn't the whole class, however. One of his students wanted to challenge Professor Pendleton and see what the old man was made of. He ran his index finger and thumb across his chin as he contemplated.

He'd teach today's class as planned. After that, it was time for a little detective work.

## 22.

By Friday's end most of the HCP sophomores were aching for the weekend, their minds nearly as shredded as their bodies had felt at this time last year. They'd expected many things from the program, many obstacles to face. Of all things they'd braced for, the absolute plethora of studying was the one that took most of them by surprise.

Close Combat class had yet to involve an actual punch. So far the emphasis had been on finding the right martial art for each member. While this sounded simple on paper, it in fact required every member to study at length the histories, philosophies, and manuals of several major martial art forms. Even the ones already trained were given this task because, in Professor Fletcher's opinion, knowing an enemy's tactics was almost as important as knowing your own. In a week they'd studied wushu, karate, Kuk Sool Won, and Sambo, with only three students finding a style they connected to.

Weapons had been even worse, with Professor Cole demanding they know the name, traditional style, and advantages versus disadvantages of every weapon in her collection. This would have been a far more accomplishable task if her collection didn't require a miniature warehouse in which to store it.

Ranged Combat was similar; although Professor Baker put the emphasis on learning to use ranged weapons, she also demanded her students begin learning the principles of climatology and how to calculate decreasing velocity of a projectile along with wind resistance.

Control was something all its own. Professor Hill instructed his students in learning how to view the world in little more than terms of a physics problem. Instead of weight, they were calculating mass and volume, seeing every object in terms of the space it occupied in relation to the things around it, and being drilled constantly on their spatial awareness of their own bodies. Most of the students ended this class with migraine-level headaches.

Focus was a welcome relief during the actual class. After the first day, all Professor Stone had worked with them on was the principles of meditation and how to achieve a clear mind. The homework, in contrast, was beyond daunting. Poets, philosophers, artists, the students had to analyze the works of dozens of them and turn in essays with their own interpretations of or

counterarguments to the pieces. These were inked liberally with a red pen pointing out the flaws in their thinking and returned to the students after meditation each class period.

Subtlety had been strange compared to the others. After the second day fiasco, the classes had consisted of a riddling tournament (which was won by Richard Weaver), an hour-long lecture on the dangers of wearing a hidden microphone, and a day where everyone was instructed to spend all their class time playing jacks while Professor Pendleton surfed the Internet. The class itself was a piece of cake so far, but that left the majority of the students with the uneasy feeling that they were missing something important. After all, no class in the HCP could really be that easy.

So it was that when Friday afternoon rolled around, it was greeted by the student population with significant gusto. Alice had solidified her plans for a girls' night, the scope growing to include Mary, Stella, Violet, and Selena (added at Alex's request). Once afternoon classes were completed the ladies took off, heading toward downtown, the spa, and a break from everything related to Lander and the HCP. This left the gentlemen up to their own devices, a gap in planning that was thankfully filled by Thomas before Nick could take the reins.

\* \* \*

Dean Blaine heard his door open without so much as a knock. He sighed inwardly; whoever it was would probably require significant time, which would lead to him working yet another late night. This always seemed to be the cosmic curse of Fridays. He raised his head and saw Sean standing opposite him, patiently waiting to be acknowledged.

"Is there something you need, Professor Pendleton?"

"Indeed there is, Blaine."

"Need I remind you that we are on school ground and I am your boss?"

"True, but we're off the clock."

"No, Professor Pendleton, only you are off the clock. Some of us have much to do and would greatly appreciate being left alone to do it."

"Fine, fine," Sean said, tossing up his hands. "Did you get the e-mail about what happened in Tuesday's class?"

“I did.”

“Well, I wanted to take a look at the video footage from the entrance hall that morning. I doubt whoever did it placed the notes on everyone there, but it’s the best place to get at their backpacks. I’m sure we recorded at least one instance of them slipping in the papers.”

Dean Blaine relaxed a little. That was an easy request to fill.

“Certainly; all HCP staff has access to our archives. Go to room C-142-L and press your palm against the square pad. It will let you in and I trust you can figure it out from there.”

“I do have a knack with computers,” Sean agreed. Dean Blaine remembered Sean’s “knack” quite well. It had resulted in many a disabled alarm system at looted crime scenes.

Sean turned to leave, but Dean Blaine spoke up to delay him.

“If I were you, I’d focus the majority of my initial video watching on Nick Campbell,” Dean Blaine advised.

“The kid with the sunglasses? Why him?”

“You don’t think he is capable?”

“Not really. He was one of the first people out in the riddle contest, so he doesn’t have much creative thinking. He nodded off during my lecture, so he doesn’t have the willpower and dedication to take in a myriad of details that seem boring. Not to mention he was terrible at jacks, so he likely lacks even the basic dexterity to skulk, sneak, and steal when necessary,” Sean replied.

“Trust me on this one. Watch him first. Just call it a hunch,” Dean Blaine insisted.

“If you say so,” Sean grudgingly agreed.

“Oh, and one more thing,” Dean Blaine added.

“Yes?”

“I know you find it tedious, but you really should read through the files of your students,” Dean Blaine told him.

“I’d really rather not. When you go in with impressions of people before you meet them it tends to taint your judgment of someone off the bat,

rather than allowing you to come to your own conclusions. Even if it's things like psych profiles and aptitude tests I'd still rather see those traits demonstrated than read about them. That's your problem; you always liked charts and numbers. I prefer to learn by assessing the people," Sean defended.

Dean Blaine smiled at him with what was probably an altruistically knowing and not-at-all-smug smile. Probably.

"If you say so."

## 23.

The girls sighed with relaxation, almost in harmony, as they rested in the just-warm-enough room. Each had been scrubbed, rubbed, and hot-tubbed to the point of pure decadence. Many of the ladies had been resistant to Alice's spa idea at first: Violet and Stella didn't see themselves as girly-girls and Camille was ill at ease being massaged by a stranger, but as they simmered in their state of saturated relaxation, there was no regret in the room at electing to attend.

"This is the first time all week I haven't had my teeth clenched in stress," Violet commented offhandedly.

"Amen," Selena agreed. "I didn't realize how badly my body needed to get away from that world."

"I did," Alice said. "I really freaking did."

"Yeah, good call," Stella complimented. "I wonder how the boys are burning off their stress."

"Depends on if Nick manage to finagle control of their outing or not," Alice pointed out.

"Thomas said he had already made plans," Camille informed them.

"They're fine then," Violet concluded. "Thomas is ridiculously responsible and proper. He even asked permission to kiss me at the end of our first date. I bet he takes them to a crafts workshop or some crap."

"I hope they have a little more fun than that," Mary volunteered. "It would hardly be fair if we get this and they only get instructions on woodworking."

"Nothing to be done for it," Selena said. "Our boys are, for the most part, just the habitually responsible types."

\* \* \*

The blood arced through the air, sailing past the metal wires of the cage and landing on the cold concrete of the bare floor. It pooled there, joining its brethren of spittle and sloshed beer where it would linger until an unfortunate and underpaid worker took a rag soaked in cleaning solution to it some hours later. For now, the blood lingered, slowly spreading into a stain



only a few yards away from Alex's feet.

"Holy shit!" Nick yelled as the blonde fighter dropped to his knee and then all the way to the floor. That last punch had sent his head rocking like he was at a mid-eighties metal concert and pushed his brain straight into dreamland. Or, more likely in this poor soul's case, into nightmare château.

The fighter sporting a multicolored mohawk tossed his arms skyward in victory, and the crowd screamed their approval through hoarse throats and increasingly drunken hazes.

"The other guy really should have bobbed to the side," Alex pointed out.

"Wouldn't have helped," Thomas replied. "His opponent was ready for that and had his leg positioned to sweep him to the ground." Over a year of experience in combat had honed his battle perceptions nicely, allowing him to appreciate the mixed martial arts match on a more detailed level than the average spectator. Of course, what he appreciated the most was that for once he was watching someone else get knocked around instead of filling that role himself.

"This is amazing," Vince said, his voice still somewhat awestruck. "I never knew that people had made this kind of fighting into a sport. All I've ever seen was boxing."

"Yeah, mixed martial arts has really come into its own over the last decade or so," Alex informed him. "Though I had no idea that a crew was going to be in town."

"It was good fortune," Thomas said. In truth it was because one of his sparring partners from back home was in the organization and had given Thomas both free tickets and a heads' up, but if one looked at networking as a type of luck then good fortune it was.

"I wonder if they accept challengers," Hershel mused thoughtfully. "I've got a hip flask and Roy probably deserves to have a little fun, too."

"Even if they do, it won't be ones like him," Nick replied. "You know the rules: our type has to go to the SAA. Which might be a good career move for Roy if this whole college thing doesn't pan out."

"They actually recruit heavily from HCP washouts," Alex said. "I got a call over the summer from a local scout who assumed I hadn't made

sophomore year.”

“For a scout he can’t judge talent very well, then,” Thomas told him. He’d grown fond of the leaner brown-haired boy, and after last year’s midterm had acquired a healthy respect for his ability.

The next fighters began walking down the runway to the ring, a myriad of boos, coos, and yahoos greeting them as they descended. The crowd ratcheted up its intensity by several degrees as the combatants actually entered the ring, the bloodlust almost palpable as the spectacle drew nearer to starting.

“Thank goodness the chicks wanted their own night,” Nick said. “This kicks the crap out of anything they might have wanted to do.”

\* \* \*

Carl Fletcher sat in the small apartment Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport had at the back of Melbrook, sipping on his fifth cocktail and feeling pretty good about life. The boys had recovered significantly since he saw them on the beach, bouncing back with the kind of vigor and determination that had led him to recruit them in the first place.

“Been a long time since we all sat together and drank,” Carl noted casually. It really had been. He’d retired over five years ago, and communication with those still active wasn’t exactly smiled upon. “How are Stop and Tracking holding up?”

“Resplendent as always,” Mr. Numbers replied. “They’re assigned to protect some diplomat’s child between situations, so they’re staying at an ultra-posh hotel in New York.”

“Tracking always did have a way of finagling the best assignments,” Carl remembered. “That girl could collect favors like they were bottle caps.”

“She has an exceptionally useful ability,” Mr. Transport said. “That calls for her services to be needed in unofficial capacities quite often.”

“Meanwhile, Mr. Transport and I get hopped around the globe frequently since relocation is easy for us,” Mr. Numbers said, a rasp of bitterness detectable in his voice. “This is the longest we’ve managed to stay in one place since we started.”

“Chin up, Numbers, they did the same thing to me and I wasn’t even paired with a teleporter,” Carl said. “On to happier topics. How’s that girl of

yours? Still keeping tabs I assume?”

Mr. Numbers smiled; not a grin or a smirk or a sneer or a calculated pull of his lips to show teeth, but a genuine smile. “She’s doing really well. Just got her doctorate in molecular biology.”

“At her age? That’s pretty impressive,” Carl said.

“That’s my niece,” Mr. Numbers said simply, his intense blue eyes shifting out of focus as they looked beyond the physical realm of the room and into his memory.

“What about you, Transport? Still flying solo?”

“You know the job,” Mr. Transport said simply.

“Yeah. Yeah, I know the job.” Carl took a deep draw from his drink and let the line of questioning die out. There wasn’t more to say, nor more that needed to be said. Carl already understood; after all, Carl had his nice home on his nice beach which was nice and quiet with no spouses talking or grandkids visiting.

Carl knew the job, all right.

## 24.

It was midway through the third week of classes when a white document appeared on the wall in front of the gym. It said very little, only listing a date and the numbers “1 vs. 4” and “2 vs. 3”. It said nothing else and was gone the next day. For its minimal appearance of importance, that one sheet of paper stirred up the sophomore class more than a pickup truck careening through a bee hive. There was excitement, titillation, trepidation, curiosity, wonder, worry, and of course good old-fashioned fear. Fear of the incoming, fear of the unknown, and a particularly poignant fear concerning the fact that the date on the paper was only three weeks away.

\* \* \*

Alex and Camille arrived at Melbrook that night around the same time. No one had told them to show up after classes because no one had needed to. It was obvious they'd need to talk with their team. They entered the dorm and found the others already sitting in the common room. Hershel had given the night over to Roy since the weaker Daniels brother wouldn't be participating in any upcoming events. The muscular man sat on the couch, working so hard to look carefree that it appeared more as though he were trying to quiet an upset stomach. Mary and Alice were perched on a couch while Vince sat near them by himself. Only Nick was standing, his narrow shoulders leaned against the far wall as he watched the two non-residents walk in.

“And then there were seven,” Nick quipped.

“Sorry we didn't call first,” Alex apologized. “We just figured with the matches being announced...”

“You're fine,” Mary assured him. “We were expecting you two to come over and talk about the plan with us.”

“What plan?” Alice asked. “All we know is who we're facing and when. We don't know anything about what sort of match it will be so I'm not sure how much actual planning we can do.”

“More than you might think,” Mary told her. “We don't know what we're facing, but we do know our team composition and the lineup of the others. That should at least allow us to come up with some comprehensive strategies for several scenarios so we're not totally flat-footed when things

start.”

“Seems like a waste to me,” Roy said. “There’s no type of challenge they can throw at us that can’t be beaten with enough force.”

“Oh? That why you failed my little scavenger hunt?” Nick asked.

“That was different,” Roy snapped.

“Different in that the stakes were lower and your failure more excusable? Yeah, I suppose it was different,” Nick replied.

“Settle down, you two,” Mary commanded. “We need to have some strategies if we want to get through our first match with the kind of scores we’ll probably need. Britney is a damned fine leader and has placed well in all of our exams so far by using good tactics and plenty of forethought. Since she’s the captain of team four it is safe to assume they won’t be caught in a panic, even if they get thrown a few curveballs. We should try to play in the same league.”

“Not to be a downer, but how do you propose to do that?” Alex asked. “Nick’s photo hunt that ran us around town did an excellent job of showing just how much we lack in the planning department. We’re all smart, capable Supers, but we don’t have much experience with having to think like tacticians.”

“Actually, I’d say that night taught us one person in the group has a tremendous amount of experience in thinking like a tactician,” Mary disagreed.

“You mean Nick?” Alex’s voice did not convey a tone of reassurance at this revelation.

“I do,” Mary confirmed. “I might be the captain, but being in charge means delegating on tasks you know you aren’t the best option for. When it comes to strategy and thinking ahead, I’d say Nick is by far the greatest among us.”

“If you say so,” Alex said hesitantly.

“Alex, I know the image Nick gives off: that he is an irreverent, uncaring, sunglasses-wearing douchebag slacker who is just here wasting everyone’s time,” Alice said.

“I feel that was a little excessive,” Nick complained.

“But,” Alice continued, ignoring Nick’s protests, “we four know him better than anyone else. We lived with him for the past year and fought against Coach George with him. The fact that we’re totally on board with Mary’s suggestion should tell you that there is more to him than gelled hair and a sack of shit where his heart should be.”

“Okay, that one was just mean,” Nick spoke up again.

“Alice is right,” Vince agreed.

“Dude!”

“Oh, sorry, Nick, not about those things, but about us knowing you and what you can do,” Vince clarified.

“I believe you all,” Alex said. “It’s just strange to hear. I don’t mean to be offensive, I just never saw you as the type to plan ahead much. Quite the opposite, really.”

“If you considered yourself a telepath then I’d take that as a compliment,” Nick said. “As is, I’ll just appreciate the willingness to view me in a new light. I’ll even tell you what: how about before we go over my ideas for prepping for multiple types of challenges, you listen to my overview of our situation? If you think I don’t have a comprehensive grasp on what we’re facing then I’ll happily abdicate my newly-acquired duties.”

“That sounds more than fair,” Alex agreed, taking a seat next to Vince. Camille slipped into a chair over near the door where she had a good view but was difficult to see.

“Good,” Nick said, stepping forward from his leaning position and taking command of the attention in the room. “I’d like to start with a simple overview of our chances as we are at this given moment, and with the most recent knowledge of Britney’s team that I have.” Nick paused and thought of how to best articulate this message that would convey a firm grasp of the situation to his teammates.

“To put it succinctly: we’re fucked.”

## 25.

“Would you care to elaborate?” Mary prodded as the others merely stared at Nick silently. They’d grown a bit too used to his pageantry to be surprised by such declarations anymore. Nick nodded his agreement and produced a set of playing cards from his pocket. He sat down in front of the coffee table and dutifully began setting out one card after another until he had displayed seven different cards in a line, face up.

“Let’s go with a more visual explanation,” Nick said. “Each of these cards represents a member of Britney’s team. The numbered cards represent non-combat abilities, while the face cards represent fighting prowess. Higher is, of course, more powerful.”

“So there are three Jacks,” Vince noted.

“Michael, Allen, and Hector,” Nick said. “All three at the lowest level of combat skill when compared to the rest of the class.”

“That leaves a nine, two sixes, and an eight,” Alice observed.

“Correct,” Nick confirmed. “This only takes into account the usefulness of the super abilities of the person in question, not any other extraordinary qualities they may possess. So the nine is Adam, the eight is Britney, and the sixes are Gilbert and Terrance.”

“That doesn’t seem bad at all,” Roy said.

“Oh? That’s my fault, then. I should have given you a standard of comparison.” Nick began doling cards out again, this time face down, one to each person in the room. He placed one down in front of himself and sat back down.

“Only a Jack? That’s bullshit,” Roy declared after immediately turning his over. “I’m in the top five of the men’s class.”

“So is Michael – who was initially higher than you at that - but I gave him a Jack, too,” Nick pointed out.

“I guess that would make me one as well,” Vince said, flipping his own card over to indeed reveal a Jack.

“If we’re so weak then who in the class has those higher cards?” Roy demanded.

“There are a few Queens, but I’ll tell you this: since I evaluate people based on the scale derived from only the skill levels present in our class, there is only person at the top of the heap. There is only one King.”

“Chad,” Camille said softly.

“Bingo, give the girl a prize,” Nick confirmed. “The only people we’ve seen bring him down were professors.”

“I can accept that Chad is at the top, but no way that I’m still on the bottom rung,” Roy insisted.

“My evaluations are made from the latest data I have. Show me something to change my mind in our match and I’ll happily hand you a new card,” Nick offered.

“Fine,” Roy said succinctly.

“I’m a nine?” The voice asking wasn’t loud but it was audible and familiar all the same.

“Of course. Healing is a ridiculously useful power in almost any scenario. The only person with a more useful non-fighting power is Rich,” Nick said.

“Oh, fuck you!” Alice yelled, jumping up from her seat. “A four? The girl who turns invisible is an eight but I’m only a fucking four? You can be such an asshole.”

“Alice-” Vince said, trying to get her attention.

“No, don’t defend him. I know I’m not the best among us, but I’ve been a little useful. My four of a power was enough to save his life.”

“Alice-” Vince tried again.

“I mean, I’m not deluded or anything. I just hate being publicly branded as the weakest, most ineffectual of the team like this.”

“Alice, look at Nick’s card,” Mary commanded. Her instructions penetrated where Vince’s kindness had failed and Alice swept her eyes to the small rectangle of plastic set before Nick. During her rant he had flipped it over, revealing a two of spades for all to see.

“Like I said before,” Nick said in the sudden silence that descended. “I only took powers into account in these evaluation systems. It doesn’t reflect



anything about the wiles or capabilities of the person outside of those confines.”

“You really think you’re only a two?” Vince asked.

“I know it. My power, while strong enough to get me here, is unpredictable at best. That means it can’t be relied on consistently so it has very limited application in any competitive scenario. That does not, however, mean I consider myself to be useless.”

“Oh,” Alice said as comprehension dawned. “I’m sorry.”

“Honesty comes with hurt feelings,” Nick said. “That’s part of why I avoid it.”

“Hey, why do Alex and I have aces?” Mary asked. “I thought everyone was either a number or a face card.”

“Most everyone is. But there are a few people whose powers are extremely useful both in and out of combat. Since an ace can represent either the top of the card progression or the bottom, I felt it was a good symbol of those with dual function,” Nick explained. “In terms of just fighting ability, Mary is a Queen and Alex is a Jack.”

“Sounds about right,” Alex agreed before anyone could raise hell at Mary’s placement above the others.

“Now, set your cards down in front of the other team and tell me what you see,” Nick told them.

They complied, and it was Mary who drew the obvious conclusion.

“In a straight-up fight it seems like we have the advantage.”

“We don’t have an advantage, we have a slaughter,” Nick corrected. “Not only do we have an additional member of our team with fighting capabilities, that person is a Queen. Add on the healer and they’d have no shot in hell if this were a brawl.”

“So how does that make us fucked then?” Alice asked.

“Because our advantage is so disproportional we know that it won’t be that type of event. It wouldn’t teach either group anything and it wouldn’t force us to use our heads,” Nick explained. “By the same token, since they outclass us so seriously in the non-combat side, we know it won’t be purely about avoidance, either. No, the only kind of event they could match us in

where we start on even ground is one where the strategies could be either battle- or tactically-based. That way each team can choose a strategy best suited to their strengths and the better of the two will win.”

“So again, why are we in trouble?” Roy asked.

“Because their team is composed of lots of people who are used to having to outthink their opponents,” Alex realized. “They’re better on their feet than most of us. So if it comes down to a game of who can come up with the best strategy on the fly...”

“Exactly,” Nick said. “I can give us a starting plan once we know what the test is, but a necessity in this type of situation is adapting as things change, and if we have to splinter that will put several of you on your own.”

“So how do we close the gap then?” Vince asked, eyes already twinkling at the prospect of a new challenge.

“We learn to think in teams,” Nick replied. “Circle up close, everyone, because this next part will affect us in every match for the rest of the year.”

## 26.

The four-bedroom house was located in a development populated almost entirely by homes rented out to students at Lander. In fact, it was so synonymous with the college that the cluster of blocks by the school was called “Lander Lounge” by the locals, both for the type of renter it brought in and for the generous amount of parties thrown in the vicinity. The houses were kept to code, in some cases just barely, but they were affordable and as such had very little in the way of frills. Still, this particular house was well-cared for. It had a fresh coat of paint and the carpets were vacuumed daily. These features spoke less of the owner of the house and more of the tenants who had moved in this year.

Jill, Will, and Sasha clustered around the kitchen table, a set of playing cards before them and a bottle of tequila in the center. Jill slammed her drink and set the empty shot glass upside down on the table.

“Gah! Wow, that is some awful stuff.”

“You’re the one who insisted we pre-game before going out,” Will reminded her.

“Well, yeah, we’re all too young to get served so we’ve got to get our drink on ahead of time,” Jill said, slurping down her beer to drown out the tequila’s twang in her mouth.

“You know, I keep meaning to ask you about that,” Sasha said, her own voice slurring slightly. “Between the two of you, I’d think making a fake I.D. would be nothing.”

“It would be,” Will confirmed. “But I won’t do it.”

“Why not? We’re already drinking underage.”

“In a controlled environment with my roommates in the area should anything go wrong and a designated driver already arranged,” Will replied. “This is a level of risk I find acceptable. Engaging in these activities without such a fail-safe in place is another matter.”

“That’s my brother the worrier,” Jill said, giving Will a side hug.

“It is merely an evaluation of risk versus reward,” Will said. “At any rate, Sasha, it is your turn.”

Sasha pulled a face-down card from the circle, revealing a four. “Fours is whores: girls drink,” she declared. Both she and Jill poured themselves half shots and threw them back. The wincing was excessive.

A door shut as Thomas emerged from the basement. They’d kept the lower floor bare except for some free weights and a punching bag. It was their area to work out without the use of powers. Thomas had been down there for an hour and a half, emerging in a black tank top that was soaked thoroughly with sweat.

“Boyscout!” Jill yelled by way of greeting. “Come drink with us!”

“Eagle Scout, actually,” Thomas corrected her. “And I’m not much of a drinker. I’d thought the same of you, too, Will.”

“Normally, no, but I am testing a pill I designed to block alcohol from being absorbed into the bloodstream. Instead it is merely excreted without any effect on the user’s body,” Will explained. “Stella will be joining us after her shower and Violet has agreed to drive tonight if you’d like to go out dancing with us.”

“I think I very well might,” Thomas said, opening the fridge and pouring himself cold water from the pitcher. He, Violet, Stella, and Will had decided to live together at the year’s inception. Camille had originally been invited in Will’s spot, but she had elected to get a single room in a dorm on campus. Thomas wasn’t totally certain why she’d made that choice, but he suspected it had to do with the safety the familiar setting offered and her timid nature.

“Excellent. We haven’t gone out as a large group since... last year,” Will said, catching himself in time. He drew a card to change the subject, a three – “Three is me,” he announced. He poured himself a shot and kicked it back with minimal grimacing.

“You can say it, Will. We haven’t done much as a group since we found out those freaks were lying to us,” Sasha all but spat.

“Not the way I would have phrased it, but yes, that is the event I was referring to,” Will concurred.

“Whatever, it doesn’t matter anymore,” Sasha said. “This is their last year here, anyway.”

“You suspect their team will perform poorly?” Will asked.

“Of course they will. They’re just a bunch of fucking Powered. When Britney and her crew get a hold of them, they’ll be lucky if they can all piss out the right hole once it’s over.”

“Perhaps Sasha has had enough to drink,” Thomas cautioned.

“I’m fine, I’m fine,” Sasha said, waving him off. “I’m just saying what we’re all hoping. Once that team shows how worthless it is, those shits will be kicked out and the name of Hero will stay clean.”

“Sasha, you need to relax,” Jill told her former suitemate.

“Oh, come on, like you want to live in a world where Powered can become Heroes any more than I do. I’d rather live in a world where donkeys can become presidents.”

“That is enough,” Thomas said, his tone no longer hemmed by politeness. “Now, ignoring the fact that we have two very good, non-Powered friends on that team you are wishing such ill upon, your remarks are still prejudiced and ignorant beyond what can be reasonably tolerated.”

“I was just saying-”

“You’ve said plenty, Sasha, now it is time to listen,” Thomas scolded. “We’ve been patient with your attitude; we all had to go through an adjustment period as well. And we understand that the lie cut you deeper than us because of your involvement with Vince. However, you need to recognize that the company you keep is more sympathetic with that group than hateful. If you want to curse them up and down the street then there are other social groups that will join you in that sentiment. This is not one of them.”

“Fine, then! If you prefer the freaks then I’d rather not be around you anyway,” Sasha yelled, rising from the table to leave.

“Don’t bother; I’ll leave you to your drinking. I’ve lost my desire to go out on the town tonight,” Thomas said, finishing off his water. “But when you sober up, there is one thing I want you to think about.”

“What?”

“You’re so focused on Vince lying to you and the betrayal you feel over that; have you ever stopped to really ask yourself why he did it?”

“’Cause he’s a lying asshole, just like every other man,” Sasha snapped back.

“If you really believe that after a year together, I think this breakup just might have been the best thing that could have ever happened. For both of you,” Thomas said, walking up the stairs before the fight could turn uglier and setting his course for the shower.

Jill drew her card in the silence that followed as Sasha slumped back into her chair.

“Um, I got a four, so girls-”

Sasha grabbed the bottle and put it to her lips before Jill could even finish. Will sighed and wondered if it was unethical to slip her one of his new anti-drunk pills. Otherwise he had a feeling it would be a very long night.

## 27.

Nick arrived at Wednesday's Subtlety class to find the room empty, save for two chairs. He observed the lack of classmates, gave a half-hearted shrug, and then took one of the seats. A few minutes later, Professor Pendleton walked in and plopped down in the other one.

"Gave me a different puzzle, huh?"

"Yep," Professor Pendleton confirmed. "The others were sent to a classroom with a set of problems on the board and instructions to solve them before I arrive."

"They might notice I'm not there," Nick pointed out.

"They might indeed," Professor Pendleton agreed. "That's really more your problem. Much like someone destroying my test to see who the really swift people were was my problem."

"Oh yeah, I remember that. Strange that someone would do that."

Professor Pendleton cocked his head to the side. "Really? You're going waste my time with the innocent routine?"

"Never admit to any crime until you know what you're being charged with," Nick replied, his body language relaxed and his smile unwavering. Professor Pendleton wasn't sure what to make of this kid. Even after seeing the tapes of Nick slipping the notes on to other students and reading the extensive file Blaine had compiled, there were just some things that didn't seem to fit.

"Fair enough," Professor Pendleton said. "I know it was you who organized that little stunt. I have video of you planting the papers on people."

"So this is a disciplinary meeting then?"

"Not yet, though that option is on the table. Right now I want to understand why you did it."

"You're the teacher, you tell me," Nick said, leaning back and setting his hands in his lap.

"Not how it works," Professor Pendleton said. "You can play these little games with everyone else on campus, but in case you missed the memo,

I'm the teacher in the only class where you really have talent. If you and I are going to have productive exchanges where I'm actually able to educate you, then I'm going to need honesty on your end."

"And if I'm not okay with that?"

"Then by the time you get back to the surface your clearance will be revoked and your bags will be packed," Professor Pendleton replied.

"It's like that?"

"It's like that. I'm here to teach. If you aren't here to learn then there's no need to waste my time."

"I see," Nick said. "Then to answer your question, I planted the notes because it was the best solution to my dilemma."

"Which was?"

"I needed to be marked as exceptional, but I couldn't have that happen in front of other people," Nick replied.

"Because of the feelings against Powereds."

"Partially, but mostly because it spoils the demeanor of ineptitude I've worked very hard to cultivate," Nick explained. "Right now there is a team prepping to go up against us in some sort of test. In all of the scenarios and plans they're running through, not one will account for me being as competent as I am. They'll write me off, and I fully intend to slip some tricks through that gap of ignorance."

"Seems like a long way to go for a one-use element of surprise," Professor Pendleton said.

"Who said anything about one use? Our captain is a telepath. So far as anyone knows she'll be the one making the plays and giving the orders."

"Cunning. How long do you think you can keep up the charade?"

"Until the day I can't," Nick said honestly. "No reason to greet that day any sooner than I have to."

"You're an odd one, Nick," Professor Pendleton said, slipping off his chair and walking slowly about the room. "Normally someone with your history and way of thinking would be on the opposite side of the Hero and criminal equation."



“You’re the expert,” Nick shot back.

Professor Pendleton paused his walk, then resumed. “Found out about that already?”

“It wasn’t exactly hard,” Nick told him.

“I guess it wouldn’t be,” Professor Pendleton admitted. “Well, Nick, I find myself with my own dilemma. You see, I want to evaluate and educate you like the rest of the class, but I know you’ll keep tanking anything I throw at you on purpose. And while in any other class that would be career suicide, in this instance it happens to be an outstanding example of what Subtlety should be.”

“Quite a pickle,” Nick agreed.

“I suppose I could tell you to start performing up to your potential or I’ll fail you out.”

“You could.”

“Or I could judge your performance purely on the exams that will come throughout the year.”

“Also viable.”

“I think there’s another solution,” Professor Pendleton said, sitting back down in the chair. “Every Wednesday at five, you and I are going to meet in this room. I’ll have some class material for you and we’ll review the week’s teachings. The only difference is that while you’re in here, you’re honest. No ducking, no tricking, no pretending. I’m putting out a lot of extra effort by doing this so I expect you to come ready to better yourself.”

“That’s fair,” Nick said.

“One more thing: no tanking tests. When we do a practical exercise in my class I expect you to bring your A-game. I don’t care how you sell it to the others, but those are an integral part of Subtlety and I can’t replicate them one on one.”

“I think I can manage that,” Nick agreed. “I do have one question before I sign on. This honesty thing, does it go both ways?”

“To an extent,” Professor Pendleton said.

“Then I want to know why you’re bothering with the extra effort. I’m

smart, I'm crafty, and I've got ability, but you and I both know that with the contenders in this class there is no way I'm graduating in the final ten."

"Probably not," Professor Pendleton concurred. "But it's my job to help you as best I can anyway, no matter how slim the odds of you walking out of here with a cape. Besides, let's just say I know what it's like to be surrounded by people with way more power than one's own."

"That part I can believe," Nick said.

"Anything else you wanted to ask?"

"Nah, I'm good."

"Then let's get to class. I've got some other students to teach and you have to pretend you couldn't solve the puzzle and show up late," Professor Pendleton said.

"You catch on quickly," Nick complimented.

## 28.

“Good work, everyone,” Professor Fletcher said to the battered and beaten students before him. Camille was already making the rounds to heal her classmates, but there were many to go before everyone would be back to normal. That was the thing about a Close Combat class: getting beaten senseless was pretty much a requirement day in and day out.

“I’ll see you all tomorrow. Class dismissed. Vince, can you hang back for a moment?”

“Sure, Professor,” Vince said agreeably. He’d already been healed up as soon as the sparring had ended. Professor Fletcher fleetingly wondered if the boy had ever noticed that his teammate always healed him before everyone else. Somehow, he doubted it.

Professor Fletcher waited until the rest of the class had finished filing out before speaking. “Vince, I’ve noticed that while you use fire for both long- and short-ranged attacks, you seem to only use electricity when in grappling distance of an opponent. I just wanted to ask why that was. I mean, if you can use one type of energy at a distance, you should be able to use others as well.”

“Oh, well, I can, sort of. It’s complicated,” Vince said, shifting awkwardly in place.

“Let me guess: every time you try and shoot it too far it splinters off and careens out of control?”

“Right. I mean, exactly, precisely right,” Vince said. “How did you know?”

“Aside from it being my element and my specialty? Electricity is one of the hardest energies to control out there. Everyone who uses it has those same problems initially,” Professor Fletcher explained. “They aren’t insurmountable.”

“I’d hoped not, but after Coa- George and I spent so much time working on it without results, I sort of resigned myself to only using it when I was right by my opponent.”

“George tried to teach you how to direct a ranged lighting shot? No wonder you didn’t get anywhere.”

“What do you mean?”

“George, all other things aside, is a very strong Super. That said, his understanding of electricity is only as a power source. He never appreciated it as the wild, living force of nature that it is. That’s why he couldn’t teach you to aim it.”

“Really?”

“Well, that and he lacked any experience actually using it himself. A flaw that I certainly don’t share,” Professor Fletcher said.

“I see. So you think you could help me?” Vince asked hopefully.

“Generally, teaching ranged mastery would fall into Professor Baker’s domain,” Professor Fletcher noted. “But given the circumstances, I’ll talk with her and see if we can’t set up some special sessions with you and me to help bring that particular skill along.”

“That would be awesome,” Vince said. “Thank you, Professor.”

“Thank me if we succeed,” Professor Fletcher cautioned him. “I can teach you the techniques, but it’s going to be up to you to make them work. Electricity is one of the hardest types of energy to effectively utilize in combat. In contrast, however, it’s also one of the most effective.”

“Yeah, I remember your opening day demonstration,” Vince said, rubbing the side of his head without noticing.

“Good, then keep that memory attendant when you train. If you can get some real control over that part of your abilities you’ll become a far more powerful opponent,” Professor Fletcher told him.

Somewhere in Vince’s mind the image of a Jack flitted across the landscape of his thoughts.

“Don’t worry. If it’s even remotely possible for me then I’ll do whatever it takes to make it happen,” Vince said.

Though normally one to doubt the hurried promises of other people, Professor Fletcher found himself believing the silver-haired youth’s determination. It was pure, strong, and unwavering. It reminded him of another pair of blue eyes he’d gazed upon so very many years ago, but those had calculation where Vince’s had honesty.

“I’m sure you will,” Professor Fletcher said. “Now go to your next

class. I'll talk with Professor Baker and let you know how we'll proceed tomorrow."

"Yes, sir," Vince said quickly, practically scampering out of the room and off to his next set of educational trials.

\* \* \*

Shane Desoto was nearly at the lifts when a female hand closed around his shoulder. He sighed and tried not to shrug it off. He knew quite well it wouldn't do any good.

"I've got other classes to get to," Shane said swiftly, playing the academic card.

"You have geology at two and nothing until then," Angela replied as she walked along with her brother.

"Of course you know my schedule," Shane said defeatedly.

"Can't a big sister take an interest in her little brother's academic pursuits?"

"I'd like to get lunch before class," Shane said, breezing past her comment. "Let's hurry this along. What do you want?"

"I wanted to talk to you about your upcoming test. I heard you're going against Chad's team," Angela said.

"How did... never mind, it doesn't matter. Yes, I'm going against Chad."

"So what is your strategy?" Angela asked.

Shane sighed again. He didn't want to get into this here, but he knew Angela wouldn't let it, or him, go until he spoke up. "It will depend on the type of test we're given; however, since my team has more people with martial specialties, our strategy will likely rely on forcing them into combat situations whenever possible."

"I was afraid you'd say that," Angela replied. "Look, I know you think I'm a meddlesome, pain-in-the-ass sister, and you're right, but this is one of those moments you need to put that aside and listen to me."

"Go on," Shane said noncommittally.

"It's bad form to reveal things about someone's abilities that happen in

private matches, so I can't really go into detail. Still, you remember last year when I promised Chad a sparring session?"

Shane nodded.

"Well, I won, but barely, and I mean by the skin of my teeth," Angela said, looking her little brother dead in the eyes. "Do you understand what I'm saying? I'm telling you that kid was not only able to keep up with me, he was nearly able to overtake me."

"That is... impressive," Shane admitted. What was more impressive was that Angela was admitting to such a close win. Chad must have left quite an impression on her.

"No, dipshit, it's not impressive, it's insane. He was able to do that almost six months ago. I guarantee he's gotten stronger since then."

"So?"

"Sew buttons, bitch," Angela retorted. "So don't lean too heavily on a martial strategy. Think non-combat whenever possible because if any of your team goes against him, even together, they'll be taken out."

"Thank you for the input," Shane said, stepping away from his blonde sibling. "I'll be sure to keep that in mind." He trekked off toward the lifts, more set than ever on using this test to show everyone that he was as good, if not better, a warrior than Chad.

Angela watched him skulk off and gently shook her head. She already knew what was going through her brother's mind, and she knew what the outcome would be.

"Dumbass," she muttered under her breath.

## 29.

Hershel sat in algebra that afternoon, his brain barely able to pay attention to the equations on the board. His mind was otherwise occupied, and not in a place it recently frequented. Hershel found himself worried about Roy (instead of by him) for a change. He knew he shouldn't be; heck, if anything there was a time when Hershel would have killed for Roy to be this focused and controlled. Still, there was something in Roy's thoughts that seemed off, dangerous even. Not to others, but to himself.

Roy was set on becoming stronger at any cost. Weights, training, sparring, no one besides Hershel knew the amount of time Roy had already put in this year. He'd been fair about it, too, giving Hershel all the time for friends, study, and Mary that he wanted. When Roy's time came, however, it was always given to training. He'd barely even seduced any girls since school started. Hershel couldn't believe it, but he was beginning to think Roy really needed to cut loose and have a little fun.

"Need help?" The voice asking came from Hershel's side. It was his neighbor, Steve, with whom he'd been exchanging notes since the class's first meeting. Steve was a nice guy, crew cut and large shoulders hinting at his post college ambitions, and had been a help for Hershel in documenting formulas even as Hershel helped him in understanding them.

"Huh? No, no, just distracted."

"Good, because if this stuff is sending you off into la-la land then I'm hopelessly screwed," Steve half-joked.

"It's not that bad once you grasp the basics," Hershel assured him.

"Then why the mental drifting?" Steve asked.

"Just a little worried about my brother," Hershel said carefully. He didn't want to give too much away about his and Roy's particular circumstances.

"Ah, going through a rough patch?"

"You could say that. More that he's been pretty focused on his work lately, to the point of neglecting things that usually matter to him," Hershel explained.

“Such as?”

“Women and drinking.”

Steve laughed. “Well, seeing as neither of those ever held much appeal for me, I’m not sure how to help you rekindle his interest. I’ll just say this: letting go of some of one’s more unsavory pastimes and putting that energy into self-betterment is a big part of growing up.”

“It is; it just seems like... I don’t know. Too much, too fast.”

“If you’re that worried why not invite him out with me and my friends one weekend? I may not be a drinker but they’ve been known to shut down a bar or two on occasion,” Steve offered.

“I appreciate it, but he lives out of state,” Hershel lied quickly.

“Gotcha,” Steve said. “Well, the offer stands for just you and your friends. Lord knows after all your help the least I can do is buy you a beer.”

“I just might take you up on that one weekend,” Hershel said. They turned their attention back to the professor as he began working on a new set of problems. Hershel’s mind wouldn’t stay focused for long, unfortunately. His thoughts kept swirling back to Roy. He knew it was futile to worry, yet all the same he kept remembering the night last summer when George had kidnapped Mary and him. He remembered how angry Roy had been when he’d taken over, angry that someone would hurt his brother that badly. Hershel remembered the days when they were younger, the days when Roy was always ready to appear and fight to defend his sniveling sibling.

Even if he couldn’t do much, Hershel felt himself resolve to do something, anything, to help Roy stay balanced.

\* \* \*

Britney had a fly in her team’s ointment. Or rather, an ice cube. Michael had been belligerent, uncooperative, and generally subversive ever since she’d first formed her team. It was clear he felt he should have been one of the captains, and honestly, even with his high rank, Britney would have given anything to go back in time and trade him for another student. At this point she’d even take the practically powerless Powered Nick over Michael. There was no undoing what was done, not until some Super was born with time-travel powers, so as Michael sauntered into the practice room that evening, Britney steeled herself to press forward.



“Am I early?” Michael asked, already preparing himself to leave and come back later.

“No, you’re late as usual,” Britney informed him. “But this meeting is just for you and me. I called the others and cancelled.”

“Oh, so this is one of those meetings,” Michael said with a greasy smile. “I can’t say I haven’t noticed how you look at me, so I had a feeling we’d get here eventually.”

“Wow. No. Christ, no. I cannot emphasize enough how wrong you are. I called you here so we could talk about your attitude,” Britney said, doing her best to remain composed.

“What attitude? Just because I call you out-”

“You’re obnoxious, disruptive, and a disgrace to have on my team,” Britney interrupted. “So let’s cut the bullshit. You know what a pain in the ass you are. My question is, what is it going to take for you to fly right?”

“I want to be captain,” Michael replied immediately.

“Never going to happen,” Britney snapped back. “Even if it was in my power, which it isn’t, you’ve blown all credibility with the team by acting out since day one. No one would trust you; they’d all look to me and it would split the already-fragile command dynamic.”

“It’s what I want,” Michael said.

“Funny, here I thought you wanted to win,” Britney replied.

That one gave Michael pause. He did want to - need to, really - win this first match. It was against the freak team, and it was his chance to remind Vince of who the stronger one in their rivalry was. He owed him for the surprise heat wave a few weeks ago and he was fully prepared to deliver a payload of hurt. Still, it wouldn’t do to just hurt Vince anymore. Now Michael had to crush his friends as well, and totally destroying them in the match was a very convenient way to do it.

“Let me handle the combat training,” Michael said after some thought. “It’s deferring to me on what actually is my specialty, and most of the people with fighting capabilities are already partially with me anyway.”

“Fine, as long as you use your combat strategies only in compliance with the overall plan I produce,” Britney stipulated.

“I can work with that,” Michael agreed. He stepped forward and offered his hand. Britney hesitated, then grasped it and shook to seal their deal.

“There is one more thing,” Michal said as they were still clasped.

“Of course there is. What?”

“When the match starts, I’ll comply with any plan you put out. But you need to know that if the opportunity for me to fight Vince comes up, I’m going to take it, all strategy be damned.”

Britney stared into Michael’s chilly blue eyes and suppressed a shiver. She didn’t know what was going on between these two, and she didn’t really care to. Vince had always been nice to her, nice to everyone as far as she knew. Still, it was better that he be the target of Michael’s aggression than her team. God forgive her.

“It’s a deal.”

### 30.

Friday has always been the blessed child of Time. It's admired, looked forward to, and savored with each occurrence. Sure, the other days get to host occasional holidays or birthday parties that make them pleasant, though poor Monday seems always to come up with the short end of the stick, but none have the consistent excitement and magic attached to them that Friday does. It is then all the more powerful a statement that there was little joy to be found in the HCP students on the Friday before Monday's test. Most were worried, some were excited, but a genuine sentiment of joy was quite the rarity.

Mary noted this as her teammates piled into the lobby: a mixed emotional palette with predominantly negative overtones. She couldn't blame them; after all, their classes were far more taxing this year. Even she had to treat headaches after nearly every Focus class. She knew Professor Stone gave everyone the same assignments, but Mary would swear she was getting ridden harder all the same. They needed a break, and badly, but with the test in just a few days there was simply no time for it.

"Listen up, everyone," Nick said as the final straggler came into the room. "We're taking a break."

"Very funny, Nick," Mary all but snapped.

"Very true, my petite friend, and thank you for illustrating my point," Nick rebutted. "Let's be honest here, we all feel like shit. We're tired, we're worried, we're just plain worn out. This year has been nothing but stress so far and that is not a mindset that's conducive to winning. So tonight we'll run through our drills and make sure everyone remembers our standard tactics. Then tomorrow we do nothing at all test related."

"So what do you suggest? Another slasher marathon?" Alice asked.

"While that would suit me just fine, I was actually thinking it should be something the entire team wanted to do," Nick said with a smile.

There was a beat of silence as his words sank in. "Wait," Vince said slowly. "You mean you want everyone to decide together? Not just for you to hijack us into whatever activities seem like a good idea?"

"That is correct," Nick confirmed.

"Wow. You really do think we need this," Vince surmised.

“We might need it, but can we afford it? I mean, our first test is in just a few days. Taking a night off to screw around seems downright dangerous,” Mary pointed out.

“Not nearly as dangerous as not taking it off,” Nick replied. “Humans can only toil endlessly for so long. Every now and then we need to taste the sweeter things in life, to remember why we do the work in the first place. Much like Alice’s spa day, we need to be refreshed.”

“So what do we do then?” Roy queried.

“Consider the floor open; it’s our first matter of business,” Nick said. “Suggestions?”

“We could go bowling,” Vince said.

“We could go to a really fancy dinner,” Alice tossed out.

“Keg party,” Roy said without further explanation.

“Okay, so clearly we have some eclectic tastes,” Nick said. “Anyone else want to put in their two cents? Mary?”

“I’m fine with anything that isn’t horror movies,” Mary said.

“Easy enough to comply with,” Nick assured. “Camille? Alex? Any input from our non-resident members?”

Camille merely shook her head, but Alex spoke up.

“I do know of a party being thrown by one of the frats tomorrow night. There’s no theme, but they’re holding it on the top floor of the Rencroft building downtown, so it’s supposed to be pretty nice. They’re got a band, dance floor, and a dress code.”

“Sounds lame,” Roy snapped.

“There’s also an open bar after the twenty dollar cover,” Alex added.

“Sounds great,” Roy amended.

“That actually could be fine,” Alice said. “The dancing and fun of a club without the insane amount of people.”

“I’d be open to it,” Vince agreed. “Can we invite our other friends?”

“Of course,” Mary said before Nick could. She was still the leader after all. “I bet they need a night off as much as we do.”

“I do love the company of Thomas and his crew,” Nick agreed. In truth, he would have nipped the living shit out of the bud of that idea had he not been on the team with both telepaths. As it was, spending time around future competition could only be beneficial.

“It will make Selena happy; she’s been bugging me to take her out when we have time,” Alex said.

“Sounds like we’re more or less agreed then,” Nick announced. “Any objections?”

“I have one request,” Mary said. “Roy, would you mind if Hershel spent the first part of the night there with me? I’d very much like to dance with my boyfriend.”

“Nah, that’s fine,” Roy said. “In fact, he can have the whole evening. I kind of owe him: I’ve been using a lot of time for training.”

“Nonsense, you deserve to have some fun as much as the rest of us,” Mary said. “We’ll just bring you a change of clothes for after the shift.” Honestly, Mary would have preferred to have Hershel all night, but she also knew how worried he’d been lately over Roy’s need to have some fun. Much as she might have liked more romance out of the event, this was an activity for the team, and that meant putting the greater good first.

“Well then, seems like we’re all set for our break night then,” Nick said. “Now all that leaves are tonight’s drills.”

Though the group’s spirits sank a bit at re-submersion into the task at hand, Mary had to admit that the overall sentiment of her teammates was improved. Giving them something to look forward to had salved the weariness in their bodies and sharpened their minds. All of which she would try to keep in mind when she raked Nick over the coals later.

## 31.

While his students drilled themselves tirelessly in anticipation of their upcoming trial, Dean Blaine flew away from the city. He did so not by means of any special ability, unless skill at booking a seat on a commercial plane is considered special in some circles. It was frustrating at times to see the excess and decadence some of his classmates took as part of life while he had to simply muddle through as an average citizen. Hallow would have merely taken his own jet to run an errand and Bullrush's company would at least have flown him first class, but for the legendary Zero, business class was the most for which Lander would spring.

Admittedly, he could have run down a teleporter to jump him to and fro; after all, he knew a few from his Hero days, but he loathed calling on people for personal favors if it was unnecessary. Those people had lives and jobs and problems all their own and didn't need constant interruption from others needing transportation. Dean Blaine had lobbied to keep a full time teleporter on staff merely for traveling situations, but the board kept dragging its feet. In the meantime, employees traveling on business got to fly like all the other humans: uncomfortably and overcharged.

It wasn't the glamorous life he'd imagined when he was younger, no question about that, but Blaine at least had the knowledge that he was still making a difference in the world. He knew many retired Heroes who had lost that feeling and it had crushed them. It was difficult to walk away from any career rooted in constant action, but being a Hero was even a step above even that. The fame, the accolades, the respect people showed you, all of it was unparalleled. Supers had been known to suffer occasional discrimination in some professions; however, no one dared to show any negativity publicly toward Heroes. Blaine was never certain if that came from genuine respect or merely fear of what would happen if the Heroes ceased to do their job.

There was a baby three rows over from Blaine, already yelping erratically. It didn't take years of combat and pattern recognition experience to see that yelps would escalate into a constant, siren-like scream once they were airborne. Blaine closed his eyes and tried to drift elsewhere.

\* \* \*

Blaine and Gerard sat at the bar, a beer in front of Blaine and a whiskey on the rocks in front of Gerard. There were many college-themed

bars dotting the Lander campus, places with Greek letters and loud music abounding freely with the intoxicated co-eds. This was not one of those bars. It was too well-kept to be a dive, but too low-key to draw in most people of college age. Blaine and Gerard were, as usual, exceptions.

“How long do we have?” Blaine asked.

“About an hour,” Gerard replied.

“Until we have to leave or until we’re supposed to be there?”

“Leave,” Gerard said simply.

“Good,” Blaine said, and gulped down more beer. He would have had to quit if it was the other way since he was driving, but he was happy to discover he could still finish his drink. “Remind me why we’re doing this again?”

“Because Clarissa was on our team back in sophomore year, because she’s our friend, and because the girl asks for so little that this is the least we can do,” Gerard said.

“Yeah, but still... a dinner party? And with a dress code? That seems cruel.”

“She’s a girl. She’s allowed to have fancy tastes.”

“We’re guys; we’re allowed to not have them,” Blaine pointed out.

“Yeah, but we’re also her friends.”

“I know, I know. We’re going. I’m just getting all the complaining out of my system now so I can be pleasant when we arrive.”

“Stiff upper lip, Blaine. These are the best days of our lives, after all.”

Blaine snorted a laugh into his beer. “I certainly hope not.”

“Okay, maybe not the best days, but they are pretty good,” Gerard amended. “Who knows, there may be a point when you look back on the day of Clarissa’s dinner party with fondness and nostalgia.”

“If that’s the case then I can only imagine what kind of nightmare I’d be dealing with that this seems pleasant by comparison.”

\* \* \*

The facility was higher tech than where Sean Pendleton had been

stored, with retina scanners along with well-armed and armored guards populating every door. This wasn't a place for Supers with the propensity for escape. This was for Supers whose abilities could easily turn deadly. In most cases of those here, said abilities had already taken that turn. The walls were concrete, reinforced with steel, and covered in hidden wires carrying heavy voltages. The actual location of this testament to incarceration was on a mountaintop far from any nearby society. There were at least ten Heroes on site at any given time, all combat-hardened and able to make the tough choices in an instant.

Blaine stepped through a final checkpoint, ignoring the suspicious gaze of the guard that let him pass. It was their job to be paranoid and he wasn't going to critique them for doing it well, even if the long and loud flight had left him in a bit of a foul mood. Blaine stood placidly as the heavy steel door before him slid open, revealing a room void of anything but bare concrete walls, a pot for excretion collection, and a man.

The man had every appendage locked down and encased in a series of large metal tubes. Blaine knew those restraints each weighed in the tons and cut off all movement even to the strongest of Supers. They also served the purpose of sealing off any lasers or other attack apparatuses the prisoner might have in his arms and legs. Had he possessed such destructive abilities in his chest or head, equally restrictive measures would have been taken for those as well.

This was not the case, so it was with a perfectly unobscured face that George gave Blaine a weary smile of welcome.

"Good to see you again, Boss. I think it's time we talked about a cost of living raise. Not sure if you've noticed, but this place is kind of a hellhole."



## 32.

The pounding on Nick's door was a far cry from the delicate knock his late-night visitor had used last time. He pulled the door open quickly before any of his neighbors could be roused from their slumber.

"You need something, fearless leader?"

"I need to know when you decided that tactician meant the same thing as person in charge," Mary said, walking stiffly past him and dropping into his desk chair. Nick closed the door securely before attending to the diminutive invader.

"I believe I was also declared strategist, wasn't I?" Nick asked as he took his own lanky strides across the room.

"You were, but I don't see how that applies here."

"Of course you don't," Nick said. "You've been a good girl lately, not digging into people's minds nearly as much as last year. I'm not going to ask why - it isn't my business after all - but I will say that it's a damn stupid idea given our present situation."

"It's because-"

Nick held up a hand to silence her. "I don't want to know. It's either emotional or ethical and in either case I'm not the person you should talk to about it. Let's stick with the matter at hand. You want to know why I overstepped my boundaries."

Mary nodded.

"Because going to tomorrow's little party will offer us the chance to peek at minds of the competition. Amber Dixon's boyfriend happens to be part of the frat that's throwing the shindig so she will be in attendance."

"Amber is on Shane's team," Mary pointed out.

"She is; however, she never goes to these events without her exceptionally close friend, Britney Ferguson," Nick continued.

"How could you possibly know that?"

"Patience, research, and attentiveness," Nick replied. "Unlike you lot,

I made a point of eavesdropping on all the gossip-filled comings and goings of our peers during and between classes. I kept track of minuscule and pointless details methodically and I did it for moments exactly like this. We can go pick the brain of our opponent's leader mere days before the match."

"It's a sound idea," Mary agreed. "But why couldn't you have asked me beforehand? And how did you know Alex would suggest it?"

"Because he is a boyfriend to a beautiful woman plugged into the live-wire of the social system and because I needed you not to be fully on board with it, which you would have been if you'd known my reasons," Nick said.

"Explain," Mary demanded.

"You're the leader; you need to come off as dedicated and uncompromising in the pursuit of victory. I'm the screw-up; I'm allowed to do things like suggest we take a day off right before a big test."

"But you got your way," Mary pointed out.

"And you agreed to it, which allows you to keep the responsible image while at the same time showing you are considerate of the wishes of your team. It was the optimum way to get what we needed while framing you in the best light."

Mary narrowed her eyes. "You put a good spin on it, but I'm still not happy at being circumvented in the decision-making process."

"If you were, then you'd make a pretty shitty leader. What's done is done, so how about I promise not to do it again and you decide it's not worth fighting over so late in the night?" Nick suggested.

"Fine," Mary said. "Just know that if you pull something like this again we're going to have a problem. These matches are what will decide if we make it to another year in the HCP. That means the future of everyone in Melbrook rests on the decisions I make. I don't take that responsibility lightly."

"I'd wager a guess that's part of why it was assigned to you in the first place," Nick said. He walked back to the door and slid it gently open. Mary stared at it for a few moments then purposely walked out without so much as a backward glance. Nick eased it shut and went back to his computer.

He was back at work finishing his Statistics assignments for November (Nick preferred to work ahead so that he had the necessary free

time for finals) when another set of knocks echoed through his room. These were more subdued than the first set; he supposed Mary was feeling less cocky this time around. Nick hefted himself from his chair and walked back across the room, pulling the door open to greet his returning guest.

“Forget something?”

“Huh?” Alice said, her face sparking in surprise. “What are you talking about?”

“Oh, um, nothing,” Nick said, feeling the unfamiliar sensation of being caught off-guard. “What’s up?”

“I need to talk to you,” Alice said simply.

“At two in the morning?”

“Yes,” the blonde girl replied simply.

Nick took a deep breath and tried to fully grasp the situation. He and Alice had barely spoken, let alone been friendly, ever since last year’s fiasco. A late night call was a strange and curious anomaly. Nick didn’t like anomalies; Nick liked to know what was coming so his spontaneous reaction was already prepared.

“Well then, come on in,” he said, stepping aside and gesturing to his room. “Mi casa es su casa.”

Alice couldn’t stop herself from chuckling. Nick had no idea just how accurate that statement was.

“So Giggles, what do you need?” Nick asked as he closed the door yet again.

“I need to talk you about, well, you,” Alice said as she started to sit on his bed then thought better of it; she took the same desk chair Mary had previously occupied.

“Fair enough,” Nick said. “I like smooth jazz, margaritas, and long walks on the beach. That fill in the gaps?”

“Not even a little,” Alice said “I’m serious. I’ve been playing along with you this year, not raising a stink about your attempts to bail on our friends, but now that you seem to be helping Mary call the shots on our strategies we’ve hit a problem that needs resolving.”

“And that is?”

“I don’t trust you,” Alice said simply.

“All things considered, I don’t know that I can fault you on that one,” Nick said.

“No, you don’t understand,” Alice said with a shake of her head. “Even last year when I thought you were full of shit, when I already suspected the person you acted like was wildly different from who you really were, I still at least trusted that no matter the facade you put up, you were a good person. I thought you were a good friend. I don’t have that anymore, and it makes listening to the orders you give and the tactics you implement a lot harder.”

“What would you like me to do about that? I can tell you it was all a joke, a lie, or a farce. I can tell you it never occurred to me to not go after our friends,” Nick offered.

“More lies aren’t the answer,” Alice said. “Not that I know what is. Hell, I don’t even know why you still act the way you do. You let the cat out of the bag already.”

“Only to you,” Nick said, his voice softening slightly. “Mary and Hershel weren’t there, and Vince never believed me about not going in the first place. Or maybe he did and didn’t care. Maybe he knew all along I’d go; I’m not sure what to make of that guy sometimes. Anyway, the point is that to nearly everyone else, including our classmates, this version of Nick is the real one, and it’s the one I prefer they see.”

“So I’m the only one with issues,” Alice surmised.

“Oh, Princess, let me assure you everyone here has issues; they just aren’t all with me,” Nick corrected.

Alice snorted out a weak laugh. “I want to get past this,” she said. “I want to trust you, at least trust your core morality again. I just don’t know how.”

“Wish I could help,” Nick said. “Unfortunately, I’m the one person who can’t. Anything I say will seem suspect or manipulative, even if it’s the truth. So however you get past this, I doubt I’ll be the one to guide you.”

“You’re right,” Alice agreed. “Because I’m even asking myself if that little piece of basic logic is real or if it’s just a ruse to get me to drop the issue.

Either way, it proves your point.” Alice rose from the seat and headed toward the door. “I’m sorry I bothered you. This is something I have to work through. And if I can’t... well, I trust Mary a lot. Maybe I can believe in her judgment enough to follow your directions by proxy.”

“Seems like a workable plan,” Nick said, unmoving from his perch.

“Best one we’ve got,” Alice said, giving him a brief smile. She left Nick’s room silently, pulling the door closed behind her.

Nick started to get back to his work again, then gave up and merely saved his progress. Instead, he layed down on his bed and stared at the bright bulb wedged into its socket above him. He lay like that for nearly an hour before he made any motion to turn off the light.

Nick truly hated anomalies.

### 33.

“You look like hell,” Blaine said flatly. The truth was, aside from his shackled appearance and somewhat dirty face, George looked pretty good for a man in maximum lockdown. He showed none of the usual distresses of someone who has lost all hope of ever seeing sunlight again. That was disturbing to Blaine, because the only explanation was that the current captive didn’t intend to stay that way. If it were someone else, Blaine might have suspected delusion, but if there was one thing one could say about George, it was that he was a realist.

“If that’s true, then hell never looked so good,” George snapped back. He didn’t bother following Blaine with his eyes as the bespectacled man walked around the room. If Blaine was the kind of man to attack someone who was helpless then it was going to happen and no amount of watching would stop it. Besides, he’d seen his former employer a few times since his incarceration and things had yet to get physical.

“Funny. The guards treating you well?”

“We’re up to beatings three times daily. If they keep working at it they might even leave a bruise on me by Christmas.”

“Oh, that legendary George Russell toughness. You always have been notorious for your durability. That’s part of what made you such a good teacher.”

“Cut the shit, Blaine. Of all things I know you might be here for, complimenting my teaching skills isn’t one of them.”

“Kidnapping and assaulting students does sort of mar your previous credentials,” Blaine admitted.

“Hey, I just kidnapped. They’re the ones who assaulted me.”

“Assaulted you in an effort to retrieve the friends you had stolen away from them.”

“I didn’t say they didn’t have good reason. I just said they threw the first punch,” George pointed out.

“They also threw the last one, seeing as they beat you.”

“How kind of you to remind me.”

“As if you’d ever forget a loss. Assuming you even count it as one.”

George showed no outward reaction to Blaine’s words. Nevertheless, Blaine felt something in the bound man shift.

“No sense in pretending otherwise. They got me, fair and square,” George said with an attempt at what might have been a shrug.

“You know, I’ve read through the reports about the incident dozens and dozens of times. Several things keep standing out to me. If you were really bent on taking Mary at all costs, why bother breaking Hershel’s arm until he let go? With your strength you could have just ripped it off of his body.”

“Damn, Blaine, what do you take me for?”

“A man who will do anything to accomplish his mission. Don’t forget, I know your full file from your Hero days as well. Something like that certainly wouldn’t have been beyond you. You could have done that, you could have incinerated Roy as he clung to you, and I feel fairly certain you could have taken down Vince with a single punch. All of which brings us back to you losing.”

“People get overconfident. I thought I could get away without doing permanent damage. I was wrong.”

Blaine completed his revolution about the room and stopped in front of George so the two could see one another’s eyes. It made sense; it was certainly logical to believe that even if a man like George was coerced into kidnapping, he would be reluctant to harm his own students beyond the necessary. It held together well, except if someone knew the real George Russell. If they knew how he changed in a battle, if they understood his tunnel vision on eliminating his enemies. His Hero moniker, Relentless Steel, hadn’t been chosen because of his easygoing ways.

“How many times does this make now, George? Five, six, something like that? I’m beginning to lose count, and I’m really getting tired of flying goddamn coach to spend my weekend chatting with you. Sooner or later you’ll break and tell us who gave you the orders. Things can get better when you do, so what are you holding out for?”

George smiled, not at Blaine, but at no one in particular. It was just a smile at having something other people didn’t have, at holding a secret you knew would be priceless if it were to be released. That smile told Blaine more

than he really wanted to know.

“I suppose I’m just too stubborn for my own good,” George said without emphasis.

“No one is coming for you, George, and even if they were, it wouldn’t matter. You know how well fortified this place is. Breaking in and stopping ten Heroes is impossible, even by our standards of impossibility.”

“Could you do it?”

“Beg pardon?”

“Come on, Boss, oh legendary Hero,” George said with a touch of venom. “Could the great Zero break in here and set someone free?”

“No. Not even I could break in here,” Blaine said forcefully.

“Then as long as there isn’t anyone out there stronger than you, I guess you’re right,” George replied.

“What are you trying to say?”

“Nothing at all, Boss. Only mulling over an old adage. How did it go? ‘There’s always someone better than you’ or something like that. Just saying.”

Blaine had an uncomfortable feeling in his stomach. It was nothing more than a suspicion, but it was gnawing at him fiercely. The truth of the matter was that when he graduated the HCP, he hadn’t been top of the class. No, Blaine Jefferies had only been ranked third. Not that it mattered anymore. What he said was still true. No one could break into this place. No one who was left, anyway.

“I suppose you’ll cling to whatever delusion gets you through the days,” Blaine said. “I’m done playing these games. I thought you might respond more amiably to someone with whom you have a bit of trust, someone who could make things better for you. I see now I should have left you to the professionals from the beginning. I’ll let the guards know to send word if you ask for me. Other than that, I won’t be coming back anymore.”

“Finally. Now that I won’t be getting interrupted maybe I can finally make some progress on my pottery project,” George said.

Blaine paid the ribbing no attention. He merely turned around and began heading for the door.



“Hey, Blaine,” George called as his former boss was almost at the threshold. “I’m supposed to pass along a message. You still owe him fifteen dollars for getting those tea stains out.”

Blaine paused, only for a moment, and then exited with all the haste he could muster. It wasn’t the worst thing in the world - certainly not as horrible as his gut had been insisting - but George’s words still meant something bad. After all these years, another graduate from The Class of Legends had resurfaced.

The dean of the Lander HCP hustled down the hall. He was catching the next flight back and the board could go fuck itself if they had an issue with the price. There was too much to do, too many people to reach out to. George had confirmed something that Blaine had always known would happen eventually. Raze was back, and he was already moving behind the scenes.

### 34.

The Rencroft building was named after Albert Louis Rencroft, a particularly bold (underhanded) investor who had helped finance several institutions of money management. This building had been one of his final projects in life, a glorious skyscraper that looked as though it had been forged of metal and glass rather than merely constructed from them. It practically glowed as the setting sun's rays reflected in its gleaming surface, serving as a mecca for both students in architecture and art alike to come marvel at its beauty and draw inspiration. Tonight, however, it drew a somewhat different crowd.

"Vince, stop messing with your collar," Nick scolded.

"Sorry," Vince said, letting his hand drop. He wasn't used to wearing things with collars, let alone the stiff, starched collar of a freshly laundered button-down. Nick had helped him choose and prepare his outfit, the blue shirt that was bothering him and a pair of black slacks, citing the fact that since this was a fancy event he needed to break his usual fashion monopoly of t-shirts and jeans. Nick had chosen grey slacks and a black shirt with soft purple pin-striping for himself. It danced closer to his actual tastes than was likely safe, but Nick figured that, given the unusual circumstances, he could slide by without issues.

The girls all wore dresses, though Alice and Selena's were a bit more risqué than Camille and Mary's: Selena's was silver with a tightness near the bottom that highlighted her assets, while Alice's was a red piece that crossed in the front and drew attention to her chest. If Alex was at all bothered by the eye-grabbing nature of his girlfriend's garb, it didn't show. He grinned broadly as he held the mocha-skinned girl's hand during their saunter through the parking lot.

Hershel held Mary's hand as well, the two more demure in their affection than Alex and Selena, yet no less heartfelt. It occurred to Vince that if things had gone differently, he'd be embracing Sasha right now. He felt a pang in his gut and tried to turn his attention elsewhere. This was a night of fun, after all. Thomas, Violet, and Stella would be meeting them at the top floor and the group could proceed to dance the night away just like regular students.

After a long wait in line and exchange of money at the entrance, the

crew was treated to quite a sight through the large oak doors separating the central room from the lobby. The area was huge, an entire floor devoted solely to serving as a party venue. There were bar stations set up at each corner of the room, along with kegs positioned at seemingly random junctions to keep the alcohol flowing freely. There was already a crush of bodies in the central part of the room despite the early hour, their shoes nearly obscuring the hardwood floor that indicated its function as a dancing area. Music was pumping from the walls, but more subtly than at most of the clubs the group had frequented. This was a place that encouraged conversation as well as alcohol consumption.

“Wow,” Alex said as he took in all the sights. “Is this what normal college people get to do all the time?”

“Pretty sure even outside our curriculum this isn’t an everyday event,” Hershel clarified.

“Point of fact, it’s one of the biggest parties of the year,” Selena told them. “All the frats have one. There’s the Halloween party, this one, the St. Patrick’s day bar crawl, the Cinco De Mayo rager, the Easter keg blitz, the-”

“Hang on,” Vince interrupted. “I admit I’m not really used to this kind of thing, but how is Easter a drinking holiday?”

“You spend a long weekend with your family on your best behavior while being dragged around in your Sunday finest and often stuck entertaining small children,” Nick said. “From my point of view, it provides a multitude of reasons to drink.”

“Amen,” Selena mumbled under her breath.

“And speaking of, all this talk is making me thirsty. Anyone else want a drink?” Nick asked.

Selena, Alice, and Alex all raised their hands.

“I’ll come with you,” Vince said. “I could use some water.”

“Pretty sure water is that line over there,” Mary said, pointing to a small stand with only a few people milling about it.

“Thanks,” Vince said, heading over without batting an eye. If it bothered him to be one of the few non-drinkers at a party devoted solely to that act then his face certainly didn’t let it show. Nick headed toward one of the longer lines and the rest of the group went looking for their friends or a

table, whichever they stumbled across first.

Vince stood patiently in line, receiving a clear cup with an equally clear liquid inside of it. He grabbed a few more in case anyone at the table wanted some as well then turned around to look for his friends. What he found staring back at him was a set of familiar facial features, a configuration he never would have expected to encounter in this setting.

“Oh, hey, Chad,” Vince greeted.

“Good evening,” Chad said politely. “I see you’re not joining in the alcoholic revelry either.”

“Yeah, not really my thing,” Vince said.

“Nor mine. A body should be looked after and kept fit, in my opinion, and that means avoiding things precisely like alcohol.”

“That makes sense, I’m just not really a fan,” Vince agreed. “Truth be told, this whole scene is a bit foreign to me. It’s where the team wanted to go.”

Chad raised an eyebrow. “Your whole team is out here this close to Monday’s... test?”

“Sure, we decided we needed to relax a little after all the hard work. Isn’t that why you’re here?”

Chad shook his head. “This is merely part of an arrangement I made. I agreed to chaperone someone in exchange for her assistance training my team.”

The word “Who” was literally halfway out of Vince’s mouth when a blonde in a shimmering gold dress practically materialized at Chad’s side. She sported a glass of wine in one hand and a frosty mug of beer in the other.

“There you are,” Angela DeSoto said, bumping Chad’s shoulder with her own to draw attention. “I swear, it takes you longer to get water than it takes me to make water, and I have to deal with the ever-present line at the girl’s room. Hey, silver-haired kid, how’s it shaking?”

“Pretty good,” Vince said uncertainly. “You’re the chaperone from last year’s river trip, right?”

“Yup, and the hostess with the mostess, not to mention widdle Shane’s big sis,” she confirmed. “Sorry to break up your conversation, but I didn’t

bribe big, blonde, and muscly here to come along and not move me around the dance floor.”

“I believe your exact words were that you ‘wanted to dance but didn’t want a dude who was going to get all gropey after two beers’,” Chad informed her.

“Well, are we dancing? No, so let’s get you some freaking water, set it down at the table, and light that floor on fire. That’s a metaphor, silver-kid, don’t go pyro wrecking everyone’s night.”

“What? But I-I would never,” Vince began sputtering.

“Ease up, kid, I’m just messing around,” Angela assured him. “Freaking A, you’re as easy as this one.”

“Perhaps it would be better to direct your energies toward dancing,” Chad said, easing her away. “Nice seeing you, Vince.”

“That’s what momma is talking about. Later, Vince, try ditching the water and having a little fun at some point,” Angela called over her shoulder.

Vince merely chuckled to himself and went to find his friends. It was good to see someone as serious as Chad being forced to take part in some light-hearted activities.

## 35.

Since nearly his first day at Lander, Vince had been engaged in some phase of the courting process. Initially it was friendship, then tentative dating, then of course the actual manifestation of a relationship. The point being that until the end of his freshman year, he had attended every social event with either the physical presence of a romantic partner or the moral obligation of having one. On this night, Vince was realizing for the first time what it was like to be single and in a large social setting. It was largely the same from a logistical standpoint, yet somehow it felt... lonelier.

It's not to say that he was excluded or the only single one; quite the opposite, really, since Hershel, Mary, Alex, and Selena were the only dedicated couples in attendance. However, he was used to having a conversation separate from the group at outings like this, a private world that could lead him to the dance floor or to the bar or merely draw him into it as he sat in place, briefly walking away from the larger group dynamic to a more intimate one. That was gone now, and Vince found himself missing it nearly as much as he missed Sasha, which was still quite a bit.

As for the others, they seemed to be having their usual amounts of fun. Hershel and Mary were talking quietly, Selena and Alex twirling around the dance floor (or twirling as much as one could with the limited space and large population), Thomas, Violet, Stella, Nick, and Alice were all engaged in boisterous conversation, and Camille was listening silently but attentively. Something about that girl pricked at Vince's memory. He'd thought he had put it to rest when he recognized her as the healer from Jill and Sasha's match, yet a bit of his brain continued to tingle when he looked at her. He shrugged it off, as usual, and let his attention wander.

"Man, I would never have guessed a girl that scary could drop it that low," Nick noted as Angela took it to the floor and Chad looked strikingly uncomfortable. "And to see it wasted on such a fuddy-duddy. For shame."

"Did you actually just use the word 'fuddy-duddy'? I'd say that's the bigger shame," Violet accused.

"If the dud fits, use it," Nick replied. "Seriously, he has a fairly good-looking lady gyrating against him and he looks like he is getting a root canal."

"I imagine it's a delicate line to walk, escorting one's best friend's

sister,” Vince contributed.

“Waaaaaaait, what the shit now?” Alice said, turning her head.

“Aren’t Shane and Chad friends? I mean, they hang out so often I just assumed-”

“That’s not the juicy part,” Stella interrupted. “Did you just say Angela is Shane’s sister?”

“That’s what she told me at the water table,” Vince said.

“Wow, I guess that explains why she’s so involved in the freshman class,” Violet surmised.

“I think it’s kind of her to take an active interest in her younger brother’s world,” Thomas said.

“Mmmhmm, given how aggressively she’s dancing I’m not sure it’s Shane’s whole world she’s interested in,” Stella said. “More like just one hunky blonde part of it.”

“I don’t think it is like that,” Vince said. “He agreed to escort her in exchange for training assistance. She said she wanted him so that she could enjoy the act of dancing without fending off other boys.”

The table stared at him, silence on their tongues and doubts that he could possibly be serious in their eyes.

“Wait, does Chad believe that, too?” Alice asked.

“Of course,” Vince said.

Nick sucked in a sharp breath through his teeth. “Holy damn they made two of them.”

“Two of what?” Vince asked.

“Maybe it’s something about being really powerful that makes them like this?” Alice proposed.

“Nope, I’m about on par with at least Vince and I’m not that dense,” Thomas replied.

“What are we talking about? Guys?” Vince asked.

“I’d say it’s more a factor of focus,” Mary ventured. “They commit so fully to their specialties that they find themselves mentally lacking in other

areas.”

“I’m right here, you know. Perfectly in ear shot,” Vince pointed out.

“Yeah, but you don’t really know what we’re talking about, which sort of proves the point,” Nick said, addressing Vince at last. “Tell you what: the song is slowing down a bit so I say we couple up and hit the dance floor. I want to investigate this little curious coupling further and this is a good chance to close the distance.”

“I wouldn’t mind a dance,” Mary said, she and Hershel rising from their seats and proceeding to the floor.

Camille started to reach for Thomas, but Violet snatched him away first. She gave the smaller girl a pointed look, her eyes darting to Camille’s then flashing briefly to Vince and back. “Come on, big boy, you can take me for a spin.”

Stella rose from her seat. “I don’t do this kind of dancing, you kids can play detective and I’ll get us some beer.”

Alice looked at her remaining options: between Vince and Nick there was no contest. She’d rather keep her distance from the boy with the complicated moral compass. Unfortunately, her own sense of ethics was getting in the way of grabbing her simple yet honest friend and twirling him around the dance floor. It was obvious Camille liked Vince, yet the girl was too timid to make a move, and of course Vince was, well, Vince. Which meant if she snatched away this golden opportunity, heaven only knew when there would be another.

“Come on, Nick, try not to step on my heels,” Alice commanded. “And you two, don’t you dare try and just sit this out. So help me God I will organize a complicated tea ceremony with full etiquette and formalwear and guilt you both into coming if we don’t see you on the dance floor. This is a team night out, after all.”

Vince stood up and offered Camille his hand. The girl tried not to degenerate into a glowing red beacon as Nick and Alice stepped lightly onto the floor.

“That was quite nice of you,” Nick complimented. “Such a sacrifice to help a girl you barely know.”

“At least I’m stuck with a decent dancer,” Alice replied. “Besides, I



like Camille. She may not speak loudly but everything she says is heartfelt and honest.”

“Not to mention you’re practically itching to drag her off to a salon and make her up like a doll,” Nick countered, the two falling into a softly swaying rhythm.

“Well, yes, that too.”

“So set on honesty, despite its failings as a philosophy,” Nick said.

“How does honesty fail as a philosophy? It keeps things simple.”

Nick laughed lightly and twirled Alice out to the end of his arm and pulling her gently back. “Honesty is many things, but simple isn’t one of them. Lies and half-truths keep the world simple. Truth complicates things, makes messes where there needn’t be any, and opens doors better left closed. Point of fact, it’s quite the opposite of simple.”

“Of course you’d think that way. If you ever tried being open and honest with someone you’d see how wrong you are.”

“Alice, believe me when I say every good liar is aptly versed in truth. Knowing where the two overlap is knowing where the spot for the greatest deception lives.”

“Jeez, you’re such a cynic. How do you live in the world if that’s the way you see it?”

“Years of practice. But all right, Alice, if you are so determined to believe that truth makes things simpler, let’s test that theory.” Nick took her by the small of the back and executed a small dip. When he pulled her back to standing he carried the motion a bit further than necessary, bringing her left ear within only a few inches of his mouth.

“I sincerely missed you over the summer,” Nick whispered in a voice that tickled against Alice’s neck and felt stronger than his usual flippant tones. Just like that he had pulled back to a respectful distance again, though the expression he wore was more earnest than his usual half-cocked grin. Alice heard a soft thumping in her ears and realized at some point during his antics her heart had significantly sped up.

“So tell me, Alice, did that little piece of truth make your life less complicated?”

## 36.

Nick washed his hands thoroughly, taking time to reflect in the serenity of the restroom. He needed to step away from the world, needed to compose, needed to take assessment of what a dumb fuck he'd been. Gerry had taught him better than that, taught him that the con and the character took precedence over petty emotions. Yet here he was, only a few years since graduation, making a moronic move that flew in the face of all that. He and Alice had been rebuilding their tenuous friendship. With quiet deference and a few well-placed gestures, he could have been back on her list of trustworthy persons by the time Halloween rolled around. Not now; now things were infinitely more complicated.

Nick had actively stoked the very fires of infatuation he'd worked so hard to douse last year. It wouldn't make her more malleable, it certainly wouldn't smooth out the wrinkles in their friendship; all it would do is add unneeded layers of complication. He'd let fly with the little quip just to prove her wrong and only now were the consequences fully settling in.

Nick pulled free some paper towels and wiped away the moisture. He tossed them into the trash and readied himself to try and do damage control. Curiously, in all of his machinations, analyses, and speculations, he never once paused to wonder why he'd selected that particular piece of truth as a wrench to throw in Alice's gears, which merely goes to show that even the swiftest minds can fall into the gopher hole that is self-delusion.

\* \* \*

Vince and Camille rotated slowly in place, each carefully moving his or her respective feet in an effort to avoid the other's. They felt awkward, though for very different reasons. Vince had merely never felt quite at home in the center of a dance floor and Camille was doing her darnedest not to hyperventilate.

"Sorry I'm not that good," Vince apologized. After watching Nick tip and twirl Alice about, he felt like his own slow-paced turning was somewhat inadequate.

"It's fine," Camille said. "I'm not much of a dancer anyway."

Vince chuckled. "So neither of us is good at this, yet we're both out here?"

“Alice is scarily capable of party organizing. I’m not taking the risk,” Camille replied to the unasked question.

“Very, very good point,” Vince agreed. “Actually, while we’re out here and no one can hear over the music, there’s something I’ve wanted to ask you for a while.”

“Oh?” Camille’s voice squeaked within the decibel range audible to human ears, but only just barely.

“Why are you in the Close Combat class? I mean, you work hard and do well, but given the nature of your talents it seems like an odd fit. The rest of us have the ability to at least deal damage in some way.”

Camille weighed her words precisely, knowing she was about to walk a tightrope between lying and merely not saying the whole truth. “Healers in general aren’t a physical risk to their opponents, but they represent a giant threat when on a team to the people they’re facing. So even if a healer isn’t dangerous, they can still get targeted. Knowing how to not get hit, even a little, can make a big difference.”

“When you point that out, it seems like a stupid question,” Vince conceded. “I was wondering why they’d put you in a position to get hurt, but I guess it’s actually more about teaching you how to stay safe.”

“That is the theory,” Camille said carefully.

“It seems like a good one,” Vince said. “You know, this girl I met a long time ago had a pretty useful version of healing. She didn’t just take away damage, she absorbed it like energy. She told me she could give it to other people later on. It seems like that would be a really good combination to have, both offense and defense rolled into one.”

“Sounds that way,” Camille said, her brain sludgy with uncertainty. So he remembered her but didn’t recognize her. What the hell? She hadn’t changed that much; she’d barely even grown. His eyes seemed far away when he talked about her, and he had a half-smile that materialized with the words. Which meant what, exactly? Camille dearly wished she was more adept at these sorts of social situations. Ultimately, her need to know got the better of her and she pressed forward.

“This girl you knew, did she ever go into the program?”

“I doubt it,” Vince replied.

“Ah, didn’t have the guts for it?”

“Oh no, not at all,” Vince said, hastily correcting himself. “I just don’t think she would have taken such a combative route. I have a feeling she found her calling helping people. She was a very kind and gentle girl. Small, too, like you, except she had brown hair.”

Camille blinked. She’d forgotten she used to dye her normally white-blond hair to stand out less. It seemed as well that he still hadn’t realized that she and his former girl had the same power. That explained at least some of the recognition problems.

“She seems sweet. I’m surprised you didn’t keep in touch.”

“I... used to travel a lot, and we kind of met in passing,” Vince said, glossing over the long explanation that was his past.

“Well, she must have left quite an impression.”

“Yeah, but then again, your first kiss usually does,” Vince replied. The song came to an end and the crowd began swapping out, people preferring the loud rhythmic music to the slow twirls taking the dance floor while the other type left. “I think we’ve satisfied Alice’s requirements, unless you want to...”

“No, thank you. I can barely manage the slow songs, I don’t think I’m cut out for the other type of dancing,” Camille said politely.

“You and I are very much on the same page there,” Vince agreed. “I’ll go get us some water.”

“That would be great,” Camille said as she moved to retake her seat at the table by Stella. It was a blessing that Vince left her side at that moment: one more piece of stimulation might have made her completely fall apart. So he remembered her after all, he just didn’t know she was that girl. It had been over ten years ago, after all. The mere fact that he remembered her would likely have been the pinnacle of her night on any other occasion, but shockingly enough, there was another chunk of data that eclipsed that fact in terms of emotional potency.

She’d been his first kiss. They’d shared an intimate first experience on that sunny summer afternoon. She’d never known that, and somehow that little slip of information made everything a bit more bearable.

### 37.

As the night wore on, minds became soaked in booze, bodies coated in a thin shimmer of sweat, and spirits lifted beyond their previously dismal locations. The dancing became more prevalent and conversation became louder as the young people began to forget their formal attire in favor of recalling their naturally informal nature. It was under the cover of this happy-hearted dull road that Nick slid into a chair adjacent to Mary.

“Boyfriend time is over, huh?”

“Roy’s been charming a gaggle of girls for the better part of an hour now,” Mary replied.

“I’m impressed you’ve convinced him that doesn’t bother you, knowing every time Roy pulls this your boyfriend wakes up with new memories of a carnal carnival,” Nick complimented.

“I try not to think about it,” Mary said. “Besides, I know there are challenges to being with a telepath, even if I do try never to read his mind. There will always be issues if we date others like ourselves; best to meet them head on.”

“Whatever you say. On the subject of mental eavesdropping, gleaned anything from our fellow competitors?” Nick asked.

Britney and Amber had both shown up and begun working the room a little over an hour ago. They’d acknowledged their fellow HCP members non-verbally, but kept their distance otherwise. The group didn’t run in the same social circles above ground, after all. Familiar greetings would prompt questions from spectators, questions that would be met with lies that could be uncovered. No, the best course of action was distance in situations like these.

“I’ll say this much: either the girl is an expert at keeping her thoughts shuffled or Monday’s event is literally the last thing on her mind,” Mary answered.

“Really? She’s hasn’t thought about anything?”

“Oh, she’s thought about plenty. The flavor of the beer, how she wishes her high school friend was here, how sexy she finds Amber’s boyfriend and the implications she doesn’t want that to carry.”

“But nothing about us. Interesting,” Nick surmised.

“There is one thing,” Mary said tentatively. “I don’t know what it means, but whenever Britney looks at Vince, she feels guilty. Not a lot, just a few versions of ‘I wish I could say I’m sorry’ flit through her head.”

“That tells us something,” Nick said. “Those two were never close, so she can’t feel bad about abandoning him after the revelation, and she’s not friends with Sasha so there isn’t any connection there. Whatever she feels about Vince must be tied to something she is either going to do or going to let happen.”

“So we should keep an eye out for Vince on Monday?”

“No, we proceed as planned,” Nick corrected.

“But what about-”

“Whatever Britney thinks she might have to do or let happen, I’m not worried about it,” Nick said. “Vince may need looking after in many contexts; however, on the battlefield is definitely not one of them.”

“You sure? She’s got Michael, after all. He’s ranked number three and Vince is only eight,” Mary pointed out. “Maybe we should give him some warning.”

“If Vince doesn’t know to watch out for Michael by now then nothing we say is going to make him keep alert. Aside from that, neither of those rankings has been accurate for a long time,” Nick told her.

“Then why haven’t they been changed?”

“They were supposed to be, after the final exam last year. My guess is our absence and the fiasco fouled up the system too much to make an accurate ranking. Or maybe it is because they want people operating under those old assumptions,” Nick explained. “As to why, well, it might make people create a few errors in their plans and match-ups. The smart money says those kinds of errors will be evaluated on the leader’s part as much as the individual fighting’s failure to win.”

“Seems overly contrived just on the off chance it might foul someone up,” Mary observed.

“Yes, well, it seems to be what they do best here. Speaking of contrived, have we confirmed that Chad legitimately thinks he is here in an

innocent context?”

“Hard to say for certain since I’m deaf to him, but everyone is collectively leaning toward an affirmative.”

“Shocking, quite shocking. Also, kudos to the elder DeSoto.”

“Oh yeah, I’ve been listening to her quite a bit tonight and the girl is positively diabolical. She’s got a whole little plan for wooing Chad without his noticing,” Mary said.

“Smart girl. A direct approach on a guy as focused as Chad would only meet with distance. I sometimes wonder what’s going on in that boy’s head to make him so relentless.”

“Go figure, I can’t hear his thoughts and you can’t deduce his motives. Who’d have believed there was someone so well-defended that even the two of us can’t get in their brain?”

“I would have,” Nick said, taking a sip from a beer he’d set on the table. Despite hollow words said about only serving those of age, as soon as the local police had done their pop-in the bar’s serving scruples became visibly lax. “I’ve seen firsthand just how exceptionally guarded a motivated person can make their head.”

“You are quite the little mental tank,” Mary complimented. “Except for your interaction with Alice earlier, I mean.”

“I wasn’t talking about myself. And you heard that?”

“Alice is my best friend and, suffice it to say, it’s been on her mind.”

“Of course it has,” Nick sighed, taking a deeper sip.

“You know, if you ever want to talk to someone about all of this-”

“Let’s keep it professional,” Nick said, cutting her off. “I’m not the kind of person who really opens up and spills my heart.”

“Never hurts to try.”

“On that account, you are so very wrong,” Nick replied. “Now, if you’ll excuse me, I have a fresh beer to open and a blonde girl to try and convince I was messing with her.”

“Don’t do that,” Mary cautioned.

“Why? Because such complications make life worth the living?”

“Well, yes. But mostly because I know you’ve been trying to repair some semblance of trust between the two of you.”

“So?”

“So, I don’t generally talk about what other people are thinking or feeling out of respect for their privacy, but I’ll at least say that right now is the closest you’ve been all semester to achieving that goal.”

“Ah, yes, I suppose I should have tugged on her heart strings earlier.”

“No, it’s because you told her something sincerely and spontaneously honest. Alice may not be telepathic or skilled in emotional manipulation, but she’s good enough at reading people to see that much. If you go try and lie about it then I don’t know how she’ll take it, but I guarantee it won’t put you any closer to a friendship.”

Nick bit back the witty retort that tried to leap off of his tongue. Instead he merely said, “Advice appreciated,” and headed toward the bar. He wasn’t sure he agreed with Mary’s assessment, but he’d be a damned fool to ignore a telepath completely. At the very least he could ride this apparent positivity of Alice’s through Monday’s match. After that he would decide on the best course of action.

It was the simple, logical choice. That’s what he kept assuring himself as he carefully watched Alice clumsily swaying with her friends on the dance floor.



### 38.

Monday morning found the sophomore students gathered in the gym, working hard to downplay their nerves and project auras of confidence. It worked about as well as a pigeon pretending to be a peacock, but since everyone was so inwardly focused, few took notice of the others. All of their professors, along with Dean Blaine, were gathered at one side of the room, speaking quietly. Soon they would break apart and the match would begin. Until that time, all that was left for the students to do was sweat.

Nick adjusted the knapsack on his shoulder. It was so heavy that the strap kept digging into him. He doubted he would be allowed to bring all of his supplies into the test; however, it hardly made sense to have a Weapons course and disallow the use of all of them in combat possible situations.

The others prepared in their own ways. Mary was quietly listening to all of those around her, Vince was stretching, Roy was downing additional whiskey, Alex was doing some weird breathing thing, Camille was glancing around nervously, and Alice was twisting her hair around her finger. At least the other teams were showing similar tells of fear and uncertainty. Nick noted that, predictably, Chad's team seemed the most secure. He was glad they weren't facing the blonde boy's battalion today; it would have been such a swift loss he doubted it would even qualify as a match.

"Listen up!" Professor Fletcher said, stepping forward as the administrative crowd parted. "In a few minutes, we're going to take you down to the levels where you will be facing each other. The events will occur simultaneously on different floors, and we will be monitoring both closely. Before we depart, I'm going to go over the rules."

If one were so inclined, they could have listened closely and actually heard tensing of muscles and crackling of bones as the students leaned forward to hang on Professor Fletcher's every word.

"Today's match will test both your combat and strategic skills. As such, we've opted for an activity that allows the use of both, depending on one's technique. You'll be playing a simple game of Capture the Flag."

Not one student was so stupid as to believe there was anything simple about the game they were about to play.

"Now, obviously you won't be eliminating one another with flags or

paintballs as that would be too easy. No, if you want to take a player out of the game, you'll have to physically incapacitate them. Be careful; while broken bones and concussions are easily mended, anyone using intentionally lethal force will automatically be disqualified. Not only does your team lose, but I can assure you we will be taking a hard look at whether or not any violators of that rule belong in the program. Beyond that, the rules are simple: all you have to do is grab the other team's flag and you win. I know that normally there is a component of returning it to your own base area; however this game is a bit more sudden-death style."

The students looked at their teammates, eyes silently trying to convey ideas and tactics before such communication was feasible to transmit covertly. Every second counted; that lesson they'd already learned from their time at Lander.

"As to how you obtain the flag, that is entirely up to you. Fight the other team, sneak past them, trick them, do whatever you like. The team can defend the flag however they see fit, but they aren't allowed to intentionally move or touch it in any way, so the flag's location is a constant. If you win, all that matters is the results. If you lose, well, then we'll examine the mistakes you made and who was responsible for them. Something to keep in mind. So, any questions?" Professor Fletcher asked in closing.

A myriad of hands flew into the air, each stretched as far as the muscles and bone would allow.

"Good. Hopefully you find your answers in the thick of the action," Professor Fletcher said with a grin. "All right, everyone, follow me."

\* \* \*

"You have got to be kidding me," Nick said, his eyes taking in the lush landscape spread out before them. If they hadn't just taken the lifts down several levels he would have sworn they were back outside. Rolling hills, thick clusters of trees, even a brook that could be heard in the distance. Someone had even gone to the effort of painting the ceiling varying shades of blue to give the effect of a genuine sky.

"It is very impressive," Mary agreed, her own amazement more subdued.

"I am seriously beginning to wonder just how many floors down this whole complex really goes," Alice speculated. "And how it can possibly be structurally sound."

“Given that they have access to some of the most powerful Heroes in the world as alumni, I’m guessing they may have pulled a few fast ones on physics to make this happen,” Nick said.

“No matter how they did it, it’s amazing,” Vince said in awe.

“Yeah, super nice. You do remember we need to get to our flag before the match starts, right?” Roy asked pointedly. He had never been much for appreciating the beauty of the world around him, unless of course said beauty involved long legs and an amply curved chest.

“Roy is right,” Mary said. “We need to do less gawking and more hustling. Once the starting bell sounds if we aren’t in location we can’t very well protect our flag.”

“I can fly up and scout ahead,” Alice offered. “I’m sure that will be easier than using the map.” Professor Fletcher had dropped the teams off in different areas, giving both team captains a small slip of paper that contained instructions on how to get to their flag then had headed off with the other two teams to another floor. Mary had taken one glance at the parchment and immediately plotted their course.

“I’m actually pretty good with wilderness navigation,” Mary replied. “Besides, right now we don’t know where the other team is, only the direction they left in. Depending on how close they are, it’s possible they could see you in the air and get an idea of our location.”

“Oh yeah,” Alice said, a smattering of dejection in her voice.

“Of course, that’s only while we find our own spot. You’ll be absolutely essential in helping us track down their flag,” Mary continued.

“Right,” Alice said, perking up. “No worries, you can count on me.”

“So glad you two could have this heart to heart; now, unless my eyes deceive me, I think I see a red strip of fabric waving at us through the trees,” Nick pointed out.

Mary saw the flag too and paused briefly before heading forward. She turned back and took a hard look at her team. They were nervous, excited, scared, and unwavering all at once. There was also one trait that shone through in all of them, and that was determination. They knew odds weren’t exactly stacked in their favor and that no one was rooting for them to come out on top, yet staring into their eyes, Mary could tell they’d do everything

they could to win, odds be damned. Despite what Nick might think about their capabilities compared to other ensembles, at that moment Mary wouldn't have traded any one of them, not even for Chad.

“All right, team, stick to the plan, follow instructions, remember the flag is the primary objective, and do your best,” Mary encouraged.

“That, and make sure you kick the ass of anyone you come up against,” Roy tacked on.

Mary gave a gentle smile. “Yes, that, too.”

### 39.

Team One gathered around their flag, doing a quick scout of the area and getting a sense of the land. They were quick and efficient, simply because they had to be. The other team would be moving soon and time wasted was advantage lost. It would have been easier if they could have tasked someone to carry or bury the triangular shape of cloth, but one of the few rules of the game was that no team could move or touch its own flag. In a matter of minutes the seven students had drawn all the conclusions they could and broken into their assigned units.

The core of Nick's strategy was delegation into set teams. Vince, Camille, and Alex composed one, while Alice, Roy, and Mary composed the other. This gave each team access to a telepath, a combat-oriented person, and someone with skills useful in the field. Nick was assigned as a free radical, floating between the groups as tasks required. Should a situation call for a greater division, Alex and Mary could go off on their own, as they possessed both field and fighting skills. This was why Nick had chosen the playing card system to explain things to his team. The goal was to make sure that at any given time every unit was equal to an Ace, either by virtue of being one or by pairing people who were respectively each a number and face card.

For this match they came to the consensus that Vince, Camille, and Alex's unit should defend the flag while the others pursued offense. The main reason was that while Alex would still gain telepathic warning when they were being approached, Mary's level of detailed hearing would be more useful in gleaning hints at the opponent's flag's location. They opted to split into two further teams, Nick and Mary going one route and Alice and Roy taking another to increase chances of finding the flag before the other team could track down theirs. Words were brief, obedience automatic, and tactics well established. The whole strategy had been kept fluid precisely for this reason. People knew their overall unit; all that remained was assigning them specific tasks to complete. It was a methodology Nick was confident his people could execute. All that remained to be seen was if the other team employed a better one.

\* \* \*

Roy and Alice skulked along the tree line, the girl floating a few feet off the ground and occasionally lifting herself higher for perspective. Mary

and Nick were long out of sight, and Alice was beginning to realize just how large this area truly was. It seemed finding the flag would be more difficult than she'd expected. On the plus side, hopefully that meant their own base would remain undiscovered for some time as well. She bobbed up over the trees once more. The longer they went without encountering anyone, not even the flag but anyone, the more Alice became concerned they were on the wrong path.

"Do you think the others are having more luck?" Alice asked as she lowered her position.

"Don't know. Doesn't matter," Roy shot back simply.

"How can you say that?"

"Because I'm not on the unit with the telepath. Mary was clear: you and I go until we find a flag, an opponent, or a wall. If it's the first one we're done, the second we beat them and keep going, and the third we change direction."

"Doesn't that bother you, that we're just sent out and told 'keep walking'?"

"Not really," Roy said. "I'm not big on any of that forethought or tactics crap. 'Charge until you hit something' is a mentality I can get behind."

"Of course it is," Alice sighed. She wasn't sure she would have preferred to be with Nick right now, but Roy was hardly stimulating conversation. The boy might be charming in the right element, but when offered the prospect of violence, his attention shifted completely. "At least we've got a good shot against anyone we encounter. I'd be a lot more worried if it was Chad's team."

"If we were facing Chad's people I wouldn't be walking toward the other team right now," Roy replied.

"Oh no? Then what would you be doing?"

Roy gave her a toothy smile, one that made her think of a hyena she'd once seen on the nature channel. "I'd be running toward them."

Alice opened her mouth to reply, but a sound like falling glass interrupted her as a bolt of blue flew by and struck Roy's left leg, freezing it in place.

“That’s very brave talk,” Michael Clark said, stepping out from behind a tree. “But maybe you should be more concerned with the opponents you actually have.”

Before he could say another word, Alice launched herself upward, working to get out of range. A few hunks of ice wouldn’t slow Roy down much, but if she got entangled she was as good as done. The air whipped by her as she bolted higher, then sounds of something tearing through the air registering just below her feet. She glanced down to see a flashing of blue arcing through the sky and landing in the grass below. She’d barely been missed. Alice flipped around to watch the opponent. At this distance she could sway to one side or another and dodge with ease.

Back on the ground, Michael turned to a still frozen in place Roy. “Looks like your partner isn’t going to be much help.”

“What, you think she abandoned me? Don’t be an idiot. She did exactly what she was supposed to do.”

“By running away? You Powereds really are a bunch of cowards.”

“Nah, we just recognize the use of roles. Alice can go up high and spot a flag easy. I can’t do that. I have a whole different purpose.” Roy lifted his foot from the ground and brought it forcefully down, shattering its frozen encasement. “My job is the kick the ass of everyone we meet so she can do hers.”

“How nice for you,” Michael replied calmly. “You really think you can beat someone two ranks higher than you?”

“Beat you? I have no intention of beating you.” Roy took a few steps forward and flexed his hands, a small series of pops emanating from along the knuckles and joints. “I’m going to fucking wreck you.”

## 40.

“We’ve got two incoming, about half a mile to the southeast,” Alex said, breaking the silence in which the three stood around the flag.

“Any idea who they are?” Vince asked.

“Not a clue. They seem to be weaving a bit about. I think they’re canvassing the area thoroughly, which at least means they don’t know where we are.”

“It also means if we leave them be they’ll eventually find us,” Vince pointed out.

“That, too,” Alex agreed.

“So what should we do?” Camille asked.

“We stick to the plan,” Vince replied. “Without knowing the size of their offensive force, we can’t afford to leave the flag unguarded. Since Alex is the only one who can sense incoming presences we can’t risk him at the outset. That means you and I go handle these two. If we fail then at least he’ll know they are still coming.”

“And if we succeed I’ll take care of your wounds and we’ll hurry back to this spot to strengthen our position,” Camille added.

“You sure you can handle this? Two versus two seems good, but only one of you is a fighter,” Alex pointed out. “I could come along and help. I don’t sense anyone else getting near yet and it would probably take them a while to find this spot regardless.”

Vince shook his head. “Nick and Mary came up with this system for a reason. I trust them both more than myself at this sort of situation, so Camille and I will go handle things. Besides, they’re weak on combat personnel anyway. Maybe they did like us and paired people who could fight along with people who had other skills.”

“It’s something to hope for,” Alex said. “Make a wide swing when you leave. We don’t want them knowing the direction the flag is in. Most importantly, you two keep safe.”

“Don’t worry, we will,” Vince assured him. Camille merely nodded her agreement and tried to calm the intolerable churning in her stomach.



\* \* \*

“Anything?” Nick asked impatiently.

“Vince and Camille are on their way to intercept Allen and Hector, Michael and Britney are still searching for our flag, Roy and Alice are fighting Adam, who I’m guessing took on Michael’s shape, and Gilbert and Terrance are blinking at random through the area, looking for any opponents,” Mary doled out concisely.

“I do adore that ridiculous range of yours,” Nick complimented. “So where is their flag?”

“No idea,” Mary replied.

“Not one of them is thinking about it?”

“Worse. None of them know where it is.”

“They don’t... oh that sneaky, sneaky bitch. She found a way to take away the advantage of having telepaths.”

“So it seems. They never even looked at the map, they just huddled up and established perimeters to search,” Mary elaborated.

“Getting rid of any chance of us gleaning the location and giving them a head start. A defense of ignorance that allows them to put all of their resources into offense. Ballsy.”

“You almost sound impressed.”

“I’m impressed by strategies that work. Right now it’s a gambit designed to overcome their biggest weakness. It does so, but only by opening other holes for us to exploit,” Nick evaluated. “But it could work, especially if they converge on our flag fast enough.”

“You could throw a little bad luck their way,” Mary pointed out.

“Too risky. Bad luck for one of them might be meeting Vince who kicks their ass, but another merely runs past him and grabs our flag. Besides, they won’t be depending on luck. If Britney was smart enough to come up with all this, she’ll have them using methodical canvassing techniques so that no stone goes unturned. Wit and skill can beat out luck when properly applied.”

“You sound like you speak from experience.”

“Let’s not pretend you’re asking questions when you’ve scoured my brain enough to know the answers.”

“Fine, we’ll just- damn it,” Mary swore.

“What damn it?”

“She’s probably referring to us,” Gilbert said, bounding over a hill and into view.

“They teleported in and heard our voices,” Mary explained.

Sure enough, a second, taller figure came right on Gilbert’s heels. He wore his hair neatly styled and spun a coin deftly between his fingers. Terrance was a student Nick and Mary had only seen bust out his skill in Ranged Combat class, however it had left a large enough impression that both recognized him immediately.

“Why, Gilbert, I didn’t know you could bring people along when you teleported,” Nick said casually.

“It’s a new skill I’ve developed. Funny thing about us real Supers, we just keep on improving.”

“We take out the weaker one first, then combine forces against Mary,” Terrance directed, his eyes looking dead at Nick as he said ‘weaker one.’ If he was hoping to rile his opponent, he chose a poor strategy. Nick was under no misimpression of where he ranked in the hierarchy of fighting prowess.

“Good idea,” Nick agreed. “You wouldn’t want Gilbert to come at me alone and lose again. Especially now that he knows he’s just fighting a Powered.”

“You handle the girl,” Gilbert told Terrance. “I owe my good friend Nick here a solid punch to the jaw.”

“He’s baiting you,” Terrance said. “He wants to split our attention.”

There was a thudding sound as a large branch dropped to the ground a few feet from Terrance.

“What makes you think I’d let you gang up on him anyway?” Mary asked politely, mentally cracking the branch in half to drive home the point.

“Very well,” Terrance acquiesced. “I can handle her for at least some time. Be swift.”

“It’ll be over in a blink,” Gilbert promised.

“Wow, really? I mean, are you proud of that one? Is that a line you’re going to repeat when telling this story later in life?” Nick jeered.

“I... shut up. I’m going to kick your ass,” Gilbert said, vanishing from sight.

Nick braced himself. He didn’t know where the punch was coming from, but he knew it would be coming hard. Even worse than that, he knew that no matter what he did, he couldn’t block it. These next few minutes were going to suck heavily.

## 41.

Roy shook off an ice barrage and ran in swinging. Michael dodged to the side and retreated, quickly increasing the space between them. He let loose another flurry of freezing attacks which Roy didn't even bother to avoid. They slowed him down a bit; however, the real problem dragging out this fight was Michael's attack style. Instead of handling things head-on like he always had, Michael was using a ranged attack style and dodging like a spider monkey every time Roy came close enough to deliver a solid blow. Admittedly, Roy hadn't sparred often with Michael in class, and given that he didn't have enhanced strength or endurance it was a smart way to fight, yet something about it seemed to go in the face of the bald boy's usual brash tactics.

Roy knew this was dragging on longer than it needed to, and the more time Alice spent up in the air, the more attention she was going to draw to them. He pushed off from his starting position and charged at Michael. It would open him up to getting frozen on vital parts of the anatomy; but that wouldn't matter if he could land a good punch. Without even his ice-armor on to absorb the impact, Michael would be slowed significantly, if not crippled outright. All Roy had to do was make sure he targeted the appendages so he didn't accidentally kill him.

Roy quickly closed the gap, taking a pair of freezing shots to his chest. He could feel the cold seep deep into his bones; however, it would take a lot more than that to stop Roy Daniels. He drew closer and readied himself to let fly, only to feel his footing go out from under him at the last moment. What should have been a fight-ender turned into a barely glancing shoulder blow as Michael slid away. Roy regained his balance and realized the ground beneath his run had been turned into solid ice. It was smart, it was crafty, and it confirmed what Roy had already begun to suspect.

"You had me going for a bit there," Roy said, facing his opponent once more. "One thing, Michael would never think to take out someone's footing on a charge. He'd be cooking up a way to beat them fist to fist."

"Michael is something of an idiot," Michael's doppelganger agreed. "Strong, and with a useful power, but he lacks any real creative thinking."

"I have to say, Adam, we figured you would take on Britney's form," Roy remarked.

“We’re weak on fighting people. It made more sense to double up on our heaviest hitter,” Adam/Michael said.

“Too bad you guys don’t have any real fighters,” Roy said. “I’m not going to take any joy in crushing you like this. You don’t have Michael’s training or experience in getting hit. You’re already favoring that shoulder. If you’d taken the form of someone like Chad or Stella you could have at least handled a few knocks.”

“It is indeed unfortunate that there are so few people with damage resistant bodies among us,” Adam/Michael agreed. “Hector’s rubbery form offers some protection, however it would have been quite inefficient against you. That’s all right; I’ve already found a way to put myself back in this fight.”

Before Roy could banter back, it was Adam/Michael’s turn to charge. He raced forward, freezing blasts flying ahead of him. Roy took one in the shoulder that formed into a solid block, and before he could recover another struck him directly in the face. There were a few dark, primitively terrifying moments when Roy couldn’t see or breathe. He kept his brain from going into panic mode with forced control and used his free arm to tear away the ice like it was little more than packing foam.

“Real cute, asshole,” Roy said, taking a deep gulp of air. “Too bad that’s not going to beat me.”

“Didn’t think it would,” Adam, just Adam, replied. “But as you said, for this fight to be any good, I need the form of someone who can take a super-strength punch. That meant getting close enough to touch you.” Adam’s form was already growing wobbly, his body altering itself to take on the new shape it had grazed. There was a swift sound of muscle condensing and bones rearranging and just like that, a whole new person stood before Roy and under Alice.

“What the shit?” Adam/Hershel cursed as he felt his new body settle. “Why am I the fat kid?”

“Oh my, you didn’t realize I was a conditional shifter did you?” Roy laughed as he shook off the last of the ice. “My natural form is Hershel. It takes a trigger to bring out all the magnificence you see before you.”

“I don’t suppose you’d like to tell me what that is,” Adam/Hershel ventured sheepishly.

“Nope, but I’ll make you an offer. I don’t really fancy the idea of beating the hell out of someone who looks like my brother, so if you turn back, I’ll only break one of your legs to incapacitate you.”

“How very kind of you.”

Roy began lumbering forward. “What can I say? I’m a giver.”

\* \* \*

Vince and Camille had been walking for nearly twenty minutes with no sign of the two people Alex had sensed. Admittedly, they had taken a very roundabout route in the process, but each was beginning to feel like they should have encountered someone by now. Part of it was merely mental fatigue: one can only jump at each twig snap and rustling leaf so many times before the adrenaline began to fade. Still, they endeavored to keep up their wits, which proved to be a very good thing. It was that attention to detail that alerted Vince to the rustle of footsteps behind him, and the familiar tingle at the back of the neck roused him to impending energy being conjured. Vince didn’t have time to think, only for a single burst of movement. He grabbed Camille by her narrow shoulders and hurled her away with every bit of strength he had.

The explosion detonated directly under Vince’s feet, sending him airborne with the shockwave and dropping him into a crumpled pile on the ground. He was unconscious before he even returned to the earth, his feet singed and bleeding at the ankles and his legs shattered in various places.

“Shit, that idiot damn near got himself killed,” Allen said, his position unchanged since he had fired the green exploding blast.

“He pushed the girl away and inadvertently stepped into your attack. No one can call that intended lethal force,” Hector assured him.

“Yeah. Good thing, too. I heard that guy can be a bastard to face head on,” Allen said.

“Him? I don’t see it,” Hector replied.

Camille heard their discussion like it was far away, her ears ringing from the same explosion that had rendered Vince inert. She slowly pulled herself back to her feet. That idiot had nearly killed himself keeping her safe. He wasn’t supposed to do that. That wasn’t why she was here. She was supposed to help him, not endanger him. She took a few tentative steps

forward to get her bearings.

“Sorry, Camille, can’t let you do that,” Hector cautioned her, bounding forward in a few ultra-stretchy steps and putting himself between Camille and Vince’s still slightly smoking body. “The last thing we need is him healed up and awake.”

“Yeah, we’re going to have to incapacitate you as well,” Allen said, hurrying to join his partner.

“It’s nothing personal. If you don’t struggle, I promise we’ll keep it gentle. We could probably just strand you high in a tree until the match is over,” Hector offered.

“Nah, man, they have a flier on their team. We’ll have to at least break her legs,” Allen corrected.

“How about we stick Vince in a tree and take out one of her ankles so she can’t heal him?” Hector replied.

“I guess that’s okay,” Allen agreed. It seemed soft-hearted to him; however, Camille had that aura of innocence that made hurting her feel like something akin to kicking a puppy. Besides, giving a healer a reason to hold a grudge was just plain stupid, even Allen knew that.

Camille merely watched them as they talked, trying to make the world become steady and preparing herself for what was to come. She wished she weren’t so frail; even this little bit of dizziness could make or break the fight that was about to happen. She didn’t have time for wishes, unfortunately. Vince was hurt and these people stood between her and helping him. She narrowed her focus down to that single fact.

Vince was hurt. Nothing else mattered. Not her shyness. Not her fear. Not her injury. Not these two warriors. Nothing else. Vince was hurt, and she was the only one here who could heal him.

Camille grabbed the coat of her uniform and clutched the zipper, racing it downward and hurling off the garment in one fluid motion.

## 42.

Nick spat a wad of phlegmy blood into the soft grass and wiped the remaining red trickle from his mouth. Gilbert's punches weren't the hardest he'd ever felt; however, the boy clearly hadn't been slacking in combat training. After just a few of them, Nick's vision was swimming at the edges and he was relatively certain there was at least a fracture in his jaw. He couldn't take a whole lot more of this pounding, not if he hoped to pull his weight in the encounter. Gilbert materialized in front of him and leveled Nick with an elbow to the nose. The blow sent him sprawling to the ground and a fresh spurt of blood poured down his face.

"Not bad," Nick said from his prone position. "I mean, if we ignore the fact that you've had over a year of physical training along with a few comprehensive courses in fighting under veteran Heroes. We have to leave that out of consideration, because if we included it then your inability to take me down would be just plain pathetic."

"You're the one on the ground," Gilbert snarled at him.

"And it only took you five tries to get me, the physically frail Powered, down here. If you fuck as well as you fight I'm guessing your only successful pickup line is a chloroform-soaked rag."

"Stop letting him get to you and finish it already!" Terrence yelled. He diverted his attention back to Mary, who had used the break in concentration to hurl a large chunk of tree at Terrance's head. As it drew nearer the wooden projectile began to glow, then it shrank down nearly out of sight as it plopped uselessly against Terrance's uniform jacket. His fingers dipped into his pocket and emerged with three quarters. He hurled them at Mary, a glow permeating them before they even left his hand. By the time Mary deflected them, the quarters had the circumference of dining room tables. That would have been bad enough, but the increased size did nothing to decrease the force they'd been thrown with, carrying them forward like the circles of crushing currency they had become. Mary had kept them away so far; however, it was becoming clear that these exchanges were more taxing for her than Terrance. All he had to do was shrink her attacks to ineffectiveness. Her mental endurance meant she could keep it up for some time, but this was a game where a single mistake on either part would create an immediate loser. It was not the type of battle she preferred to engage in.



“You heard your boss, Gilbert, better finish me off,” Nick said, nimbly rising back to his feet. “I don’t think he wants to keep trying his luck with Mary.”

“Don’t be an idiot, Terrance is clearly winning,” Gilbert shot back.

“Only if you ignore the fact that sooner or later he’ll run out of stuff to throw. Not to mention Mary doesn’t have to throw things at him, she can just pick him up and smash him to the ground,” Nick bluffed. She couldn’t use that strategy against someone as frail as Terrance safely, but there was no reason they needed to know that.

“If she could do that she would have,” Gilbert said.

“Maybe. Or more likely she’s keeping him occupied so you and I can have our little dance. See, I’m going to beat you, Gilbert, because sooner or later you’ll make a mistake and I’ll capitalize. If you were a better fighter maybe you could knock me out, but since this is all you’ve got I think we both know it’s just a matter of time.”

“You talk a lot of shit for a guy with blood all over his uniform,” Gilbert said. He kept his voice calm but the antsy way he shifted his weight told Nick that his ploy was working.

“A brilliant red testament to your failure. Each drop a symbol of my resilience and your weakness, because even with all this loss of life fluids, I’m still awake to call you a bitch.”

Gilbert didn’t reply this time, instead he teleported behind Nick. He resisted the urge strike him and forced himself to think smart. Nick was baiting him to prolong the battle. He wanted Gilbert to keep chipping away at him while Mary ran Terrance out of ammunition. Gilbert wasn’t going to play along; he’d shut Nick’s every yapping face hole using strategy. Gilbert leapt onto Nick’s back and sealed his right arm around the slender boy’s neck while his left palm drove the sandy-haired head forward. Gilbert circled Nick’s diaphragm with his own short legs and squeezed forcefully. This would drive the air out of Nick while Gilbert’s neck lock kept him from getting a new supply. It was a risky move that a trained combatant could navigate out of, however, Gilbert was certain someone as weak as Nick would be unconscious before he could work his way free.

Sure enough, Nick collapsed backward onto the ground and gasped as the majority of his oxygen was driven from his body. Gilbert smiled ruefully at his victory as he felt Nick’s body tremble on top of his own and couldn’t

resist a bit of taunting.

“Where’s that constant chatter now? Don’t have anything to say before you pass out?”

Nick let out a ragged gasp that contained two barely audible words. If one hadn’t been as close as Gilbert it would sound like a breath someone had stuffed syllables into. To him, in a moment that would haunt his memories, they formed two perfect conjugations that made no sense for the span of about a second.

“Got... you...”

Gilbert’s head exploded in pain as his whole body began to tremor uncontrollably. His grip was destroyed, but by the time he lost contact with Nick’s body Gilbert was already unconscious. Nick was too, lying a few inches away with a taser clutched tightly in his hand, the metal prongs pressed forcefully against his own leg. It was the only weapon he’d been allowed to keep from his original backpack of tricks and he’d hidden it in his pocket as soon as they were on the field. Gilbert was an impossible opponent to get the drop on due to his constant jumping about, and Nick had known that from the beginning. Even tricking him into using a hold would have been useless if he’d seen a counter coming. If the attack could be concealed, on the other hand, conducted through his own body, Nick would be able to take away the teleporter’s advantage. It was still a difficult and painful proposition, which might explain why Nick’s electrocuted and unconscious body nonetheless sported a grin some might describe as “shit-eating.”

“Well then,” Mary said calmly. “Now that those two are done, I suppose that just leaves you and me.”

“Bring it on, I can go all day,” Terrance said. If he could make his stock last until Gilbert woke up then this fight could still be salvaged.

“Actually, you can’t. Funny thing about keeping all of your stuff to throw in your pockets: they can be ripped open and their contents can be covertly stolen away while you’re distracted.”

Terrance felt his stomach drop to his feet. He reached into the pocket he’d been using and found it intact, with a single dime remaining. Investigation of his other pockets revealed the unfortunate truth that they’d been torn along the seams and his entire stockpile was now absent from his body.

“I can still neutralize anything you throw,” Terrance said nervously.

“I don’t know about anything,” Mary replied. Terrance felt a firm force take hold of his coat and pants, jerking him several feet into the air. “I’m pretty sure you can’t shrink the ground when it’s racing toward you.”

“This, this is lethal force!” Terrance yelled.

“No, no, you’re only one story up. You’ll survive with at most a broken ankle or leg. As long as you land on your feet, anyway.”

“You could have done this all along,” Terrance realized. “Why didn’t you?”

“It’s been brought to my attention recently that I need to improve my level of control. Fighting you is pretty good practice at that. We should spar sometime when this is all over,” Mary offered cordially.

The grip on Terrance’s clothes vanished and he found himself tumbling rapidly toward the ground. No question about it, this was going to smart.

## 43.

“What the hell are you doing?” Hector asked as Camille’s coat wafted gently to the ground. She paid him no attention, seizing her pants by the waistband and undoing a series of concealed buckles on the interior of each side. She jerked outward, separating the snaps that ran down the legs and tossed her now-halved slacks to the grass. She stood before them in a pair of biker shorts and a sports bra. She felt a flush creeping over her as they stared; she was all-too aware of how little clothing now covered her. She took a deep draw of air and felt the elastic of the bra dig into her chest. Her breasts were larger than her frame would indicate, and the pressure pushing down on them made every breath just a touch more ragged.

“This took an interesting turn,” Allen said.

“Our uniforms don’t have zippers and snaps. Did you customize yours just to be able to strip it off?” Hector questioned.

Camille addressed neither, instead she began running toward Vince as fast as she could. If she made a dash for one of her two opponents they would suspect something. Forcing them to block her, however, would ensure at least one of them got in range.

Sure enough, Hector stretched his arms outward, cutting off any path she might have to her fallen ally. Camille never hesitated, she kept running until she careened into his right arm, his long elastic fingers encircling her bare torso as he pulled her away from Vince.

“Nice distraction, but did you really think we’d let you-GAAAHHH!” Hector’s words were cut off by a tortured scream that was ripped from his throat. Allen could only watch as his partner released the girl and collapsed to the ground. Something was wrong. Hector was bleeding and his arms and legs were twisted in awkward directions. Generally, Hector could move his appendages without regard to joint limitations, but it was always a smooth appearance, like stretched taffy. This looked like someone had ripped that same taffy apart and haphazardly slapped it back together at all the wrong angles.

“What... what did you do?” Allen said slowly. “You’re a healer, you can’t hurt Hector like that.”

Camille remained silent. The only response she gave was to step away

from Hector's mercifully unconscious body and begin to approach Allen. She took three tentative steps then charged. Allen hurled a series of green bolts at her feet, but Camille deftly sidestepped them with grace he never would have expected. Gone was the slow-moving girl with the gentle demeanor; in her place was a relentless stampede of skin and flowing hair. She threw a hand out, as if to grab him, and Allen rolled to the side on instinct. She shouldn't be able to hurt him, but shouldn't didn't mean a damn thing when Hector's sundered body was less than twenty feet away.

Allen reoriented himself as he stood, barely getting a chance to leap away as Camille spun on her heels and came rushing back at him. He tried to send a bolt at her, but now he was playing defense and aiming came second to dodging. She whirled around and came at him again. This time Allen took an extra second to line up his shot before moving. That second cost him everything. A bolt of relatively-weak energy exploded against Camille's shoulder and Allen slid to the side. He barely registered the small fingers that brushed his neck, but he definitely noticed what immediately followed. His left ankle bone exploded within the skin, dropping him to the ground in pain and hobbling his movements quite efficiently.

He looked up to see the girl pressing her hand to the burn mark on her shoulder. A gentle light came over it as the singed skin became pink and healthy once more. If he'd used a stronger blast, he could have ripped that shoulder clean from its socket; however, that would have constituted lethal force. As his ankle throbbed again, part of Allen wished he'd done it anyway.

"You're a damn healer," Allen cursed at her. "You aren't supposed to be able to injure people."

"I'm not a healer," Camille said as she walked briskly toward him. She had no inclination to give him time to focus and fight back. The pain would mar his concentration for now, but sooner or later he'd work through it. "I'm an absorber. I hold injury the same way Vince holds energy, and healing people all last year has given me quite a supply to work with."

"That's why you stripped. You need to touch us skin to skin. Hector couldn't grab you without touching some part of you," Allen said as comprehension finally dawned. "And that's why no one knows this about you. You spent all last year under the radar just so you could build up a backlog of damage."

"I do apologize," Camille said as she closed what remained of the gap between them. She hunkered down and cupped his face gently in her hand.

“I’ll heal you as soon as our match is over. I don’t want anyone to suffer unnecessarily.”

“Kiss my ass if you think I’m letting you heal me. You’re not getting this damage back; I’ll use someone else. And I’m telling everyone about this so your little trick won’t work anymore,” Allen threatened. It wasn’t much, but he couldn’t go out without saying something. This defeat was already embarrassing enough; his pride refused to let him be silent.

“Do what you please,” Camille said softly. “Tell people what you want. Just make sure you understand, I have plenty of damage left to give, and I will do whatever it takes to protect my V-, teammates.”

Allen might have asked about that verbal slip had his world not dissolved into a cacophony of thunderous pain.

\* \* \*

Alex felt Allen’s conciseness slip away from his position back at the flag. He glanced at his watch nervously. Alex knew Camille had been victorious, somehow, so she’d heal Vince and the two would be returning shortly. The problem was that there were two more presences coming toward him, and more importantly, toward the flag. They were using the same thorough, time-consuming pattern as the previous two, but they’d get here eventually. Alex wasn’t sure that Vince and Camille would have time to return and go scout in a roundabout enough way to conceal their direction before the enemies were close enough to find the flag. He weighed his options carefully before settling on a choice.

Alex would go meet the new people head on. Even if he failed to stop them, it would at least give Vince and Camille enough time to return. Plus, if Alex could take at least one of them down then a lone fighter would be no match for Vince. It was the logical choice and it adhered to the strategy. Now he just had to hope it was the right one.

## 44.

“You think you might have gone a little overboard back there?” Alice asked as she and Roy trudged along.

“What do you mean? He changed back so I kept my word. I only broke one leg.”

“Yeah, I think ‘break’ sort of fails as an accurate descriptor there. ‘Shattered,’ ‘decimated,’ annihilated,’ these are words I might apply to what you did.”

“You’re being overdramatic. All I did was grab his leg and squeeze,” Roy defended. “There’s no room for squeamish stomachs in these competitions.”

“I suppose so,” Alice said reluctantly. “Makes me a little glad I’m not responsible for handling those situations.”

“Don’t knock it ‘til you’ve tried it.”

“I think it’d take a pretty miraculous set of circumstances for me to try it,” Alice pointed out.

“I guess so. Man, we haven’t run into anyone since Adam. Where the hell is everyone else? I’m going to be really pissed if that’s the only action I get all day.”

“They’re less combat-oriented than us. We didn’t expect them to come charging out in a full force attack.”

“I know; a man can still hope.”

“I’ll just stick to hoping we find the flag soon. The less people we see, the more I worry about them closing in on our base.”

“Nothing we can do about that,” Roy said with a shrug. “We’ve got our job and the others have theirs. We’ll just have to hope they’re as good at it as we are.”

“On that note, I’m going to fly up and take a look,” Alice said, rising off the ground. She moved carefully, cresting the tree line slowly and scanning the world below for any signs of movement. Nothing caught her eye, but when your opponent’s captain could become invisible that didn’t

mean much. Alice lowered back to the earth after only a few seconds.

“No people visible around us, but there’s a clearing a ways ahead I want to check out. It looks similar to how the one around our base was set up.”

“Lead on, then,” Roy said cheerfully. The closer they got to the enemy’s flag, the better chance he’d get another fight. That thought made him perfectly happy to comply.

\* \* \*

“You’re heavier than you look, anyone ever tell you that?” Mary asked as Nick leaned against her shoulders.

“Thanks, Mary, now on top of bruises and taser burn marks I’ve got a weight complex,” Nick shot back. “When we’re done here I’m going to have to purge and it’s all your fault.”

“You’re hilarious. Seriously, I get the feeling that narrow frame is hiding more muscle than a person would guess.”

“That is sexual harassment and I’m telling Hershel.”

“You know, I don’t have to let you lean on me.”

“No one is perfect; I guess I can let it slide this once,” Nick backtracked quickly. “How is everyone doing, anyway?”

“Roy and Alice are making good progress, Camille is about to heal Vince back from unconsciousness but they won their fight, and Alex is on his way to intercept Michael and Britney before they get close to base.”

“Vince got knocked out, huh? I’m curious how Camille managed to pull it out of the fire. Vince must have left them barely standing.”

“Actually, it seems Vince was taken out before the fight even began,” Mary told him. “We’re going to need to have a talk with Camille about holding back on us.”

“How bad?”

“Let’s just say you’ll be giving her a new card.”

“Huh. It’s always the quiet ones. Think we’re getting close to their flag?”



“No idea, but if Alex manages to bring down the last two then we’ve got all the time in the world to hunt,” Mary pointed out.

“Alex versus Britney and Michael. Maybe we should hurry,” Nick suggested.

Mary didn’t bother replying. Instead she quickened her pace and wondered if Nick’s uniform was sturdy enough for her to drag him along with her substantial brain instead of her meager brawn.

\* \* \*

Vince moaned groggily as he came back into the world of the waking. He found himself with his head in Camille’s lap, staring up at her as his vision cleared. She’d taken the time to change back and move him away from the battered bodies of their opponents, so as his brain began to come together, only a single thought pierced his mind.

“Are you okay?” Vince asked immediately.

“Pretty sure that’s supposed to be my line,” Camille said with a gentle grin. “I’m fine. How are you?”

“I feel good,” Vince replied hurriedly. “Should I be laying here like this? What about our enemies?”

“They’re taken care of,” Camille assured him. “We can go back whenever you feel ready to walk.”

Vince slowly pulled himself to a sitting position and found the last of his head fog had already dissipated. “What do you mean, taken care of?”

“I mean they aren’t a problem anymore. You saved me, and I was able to handle the fight.”

“You were? I mean, I don’t want to say that you couldn’t, but-”

“I did tell you I’d been doing martial arts for years,” Camille pointed out.

“I guess you did. Who did you fight?”

“Allen and Hector. Allen is the one who threw the explosion at you. How did you know it was coming anyway?”

“It’s hard to explain. Mostly just that when you deal with energy as much as I do you learn the little signs it gives off when impending,” Vince

said.

“Well, I’m glad you noticed it. Thank you for pushing me out of the way, but you shouldn’t have put yourself in danger like that.”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” Vince said as he moved his body all the way to standing. He looked back at the kneeling girl and offered her a hand up. “I’m the combat side of our team. It’s my job to keep you out of harm’s way. I’m going to protect you, no matter what. Next time I’ll just try to be better at it and stay conscious.”

Camille looked at him, towering over her as he smiled reassuringly. All these years, and here they were in the same position. It made her heart ache, just a bit, at how much he still looked the same as that day. She grabbed his hand and pulled herself vertical. Vince would do anything to protect her, which just meant she had to get even stronger so he’d never have to. She wouldn’t let him get hurt anymore. Not for her.

“Let’s get back to Alex,” Camille suggested softly.

## 45.

Alex walked for about fifteen minutes before he began to draw near to his opponents. In truth, the travel time should have been roughly half of that, however, he'd stuck to protocol and looped around as instructed. He could feel Vince and Camille heading back toward the flag, which relaxed him a little. He hated leaving the place undefended. The closer he got to the interception point, the more he hoped they wouldn't have to do anything. If Vince and a healer could take down two, then Alex might be able to as well. At the very least, he would defeat one and hobble the other.

Alex moved silently as he drew near the enemies. He didn't have much practice with skulking, especially not through forests; however, he did have the advantage of knowing the others were there. That would hopefully enable him to get the drop on whoever these people were. It was easier to recognize the minds of people he spent a lot of time with, but when it was just fellow classmates, all he got were hints. One of the minds was incredibly focused, straining to hear every rustle and snap in the woods around it. The other was cavalier, uncaring save for a burning, violent desire emanating deep with its reaches. Alex knew if he wanted to utilize his advantage properly, he had to prioritize which opponent to take out first. The focused one seemed the more dangerous of the two, so Alex levitated a hefty log to his side and prepared to strike.

He burst through the woods to find not two enemies staring at him, but one. Michael blinked in surprise as Alex and a floating log came vaulting from the tree line. For the barest of moments, Alex forgot that Britney could become invisible and was confused by the absence of someone he'd sensed. He let his eyes sweep across the area, trying to find the missing presence. The mistake lasted less than a full second; however, even that was too much.

The first blue blast struck him square in the chest, the cold creeping through his bones and making every breath difficult as his torso refused to expand. The next one took him in the left leg, sealing him in place before he could move. Alex whipped the log toward Michael while he still had his concentration, but the poor piece of wood splintered against the armor of ice now encircling Michael's body.

Michael froze the other leg next, just for good measure, though as Alex's teeth began to chatter it was clear fighting off the chill seeping through

him would sap a healthy amount of his mental resources.

“Nice effort, weirdo,” Michael said as he closed the gap between them. Alex tried to fight through the sensation of numbness and grab hold of Michael with his power. Before he got a chance, Michael’s ice encased fist slammed violently into Alex’s face. There was an audible crack in Alex’s head as he felt something in his cheek give way. He might have come back with a witty, if not slightly slurred, retort, had Michael not followed with two more blows to his head. His brain felt like it was filling with mercury and his entire face burned with pain. Even if there were anything to throw, Alex could barely focus on the image in front him, let alone on fighting back. It occurred to him, fleetingly, that this was why Coach George had them fight so much last year without their powers. He wanted them to get accustomed to working through the fog of pain. Alex wished he’d learned that lesson better.

“Take it easy,” Britney’s voice cautioned from somewhere over his shoulder.

“Fuck that; this kid can break through ice with his mind if I just freeze him. I have to make sure that brain of his is too scrambled to get back in the game.” Michael punctuated this statement with a solid left hook directly into Alex’s ear. Had he not been frozen into a standing position, Alex’s body would have tumbled to the ground as he passed out. Instead his head merely plopped softly against his chest.

“Look, he’s out, you’re done,” Britney said, this time less a request than an order.

“I’ll decide when I’m done,” Michael said, rearing back again. An invisible hand wrapped around his elbow, pulling it back.

“We have a deal, Michael. You want to win? That means you can’t get us disqualified. Keep pounding on his brain like this and I guarantee we get taken out of the competition.”

“I call getting tossed out for being too strong a win,” Michael spat back, not relaxing his arm one bit.

Britney sank her teeth into her lower lip. She had to get his attention off Alex or this was going to be bad. Unfortunately, she only knew one way to do that. She had to shift it elsewhere, to someone less likely to be immediately killed. She hoped that, if he were here, he’d understand.

“Fine, you want to end this then go ahead. I just thought you were

going after the big fish. I mean, Alex here is barely considered a combatant by anyone. Isn't that why you had your sights set on Vince?"

Slowly, so damned slowly, the tension in Michael's arm decreased. He lowered it to his side. For a moment there was no sound except the slow drip of water running down the ice blocks encasing Alex.

"Let's go," Michael said at last, stepping around Alex and walking forward without so much as a single glance backward. His armor began to disintegrate, falling away in chunks that littered the grass behind him. Britney let out a breath she didn't realize she'd been holding. That had been far, far too close. If anyone besides herself had been here... she didn't want to think about what might have happened to Alex. When this was over, she resolved herself to talk with Professor Fletcher or Dean Blaine. It didn't matter if it weakened her team; Michael had no place in the HCP.

She only hoped she could get them through this ordeal before he bloodily proved that to everyone.

## 46.

“Alex is gone,” Camille noticed as she and Vince arrived back at the flag.

“He only would have left if other people were approaching,” Vince said. “The plan was always to have someone here if possible.”

“Maybe we shouldn’t be standing out in the open then, just in case,” Camille suggested.

“Good idea,” Vince agreed. “If Alex comes back he’ll know we’re here. If someone else wanders by, well, we’ve already seen the value of surprise demonstrated today.”

“I guess we have,” Camille said. The duo headed for the tree line where they blended in as best as their grey uniforms would allow.

\* \* \*

“Hurry up,” Alice urged as Roy jogged behind her.

“Look, Floaty, some of us have to actually navigate the terrain here,” Roy said as he leapt over a fallen log and quickened his pace. True, he didn’t have to deal with normal things like muscle fatigue or shortness of breath, but that still didn’t mean he could keep up with a girl zipping through the air.

“Sorry, I’m just starting to get worried,” Alice said. “The longer we go without seeing anyone the more I think that they all went offensive and are headed toward our base.”

“If they did then they did. Nothing we can do to help them out at this point.”

“We can find their flag,” Alice pointed out.

“Fine,” Roy said, stepping up his jog to a flat out run. “Fair warning, if we hurry our asses into an ambush, I’m blaming you.”

“That’s fair,” Alice said. She lifted up higher into the air and surveyed the landscape, looking for the slightest hint of their objective.

\* \* \*

Michael saw the flag first, dashing ahead to confirm what his eyes

suspected was a piece of fabric being flicked by the wind. He stepped into the clearing and stopped, a sense of disappointment filling him. There it was, the goal, the objective, the game finisher. His team was going to win, but he hadn't gotten the rematch he really wanted.

"Fuck all," Michael muttered under his breath. He started the slow, steady march toward the flag and his now inevitable victory.

If his opponent had been anyone else, that would have been the end of Michael's day. Roy, Alex, even Mary would have utilized the opportunity to strike without warning. They would have brought him down before he had a chance to react. They weren't there, however, and so what next impacted Michael was a set of words rather than an attack.

"I had a feeling you'd be on the offensive," Vince said as he stepped out from the trees. He was slightly closer to the flag than Michael, but if the bald boy made a dash, it would be a close race. In his peripheral vision, Vince saw Camille edging along the side of the clearing. She was getting closer in case Vince needed help on the interception. He wished he could tell her to stay out of the way where it was safe. Michael was a dangerous opponent; it was best he kept all of his attention on Vince.

"Happy birthday to me," Michael said, showing a grin that flirted with deranged. He angled his body so that he was facing the silver-haired boy dead on. "I was hoping for this." Fresh armor crackled over him as he spoke, splintering and fissuring in key places to allow movement. No surprise heat wave was going to stop him this time. Here, at last, they were facing each other on even ground for the first time since their initial fight all the back in freshman year. This was where Michael would finally prove that his win was no fluke, that he was and always would be the stronger warrior.

"I guess telling you this is pointless would be a waste of my breath," Vince sighed. He wasn't looking forward to what was coming next.

"I don't know about a waste. I find begging to be a fine pre-fight appetizer. But let's be honest, both of us are really here for the main course." Michael let fly with a series of punches, sending blue bolts hurtling across the clearing. Vince took off running, going the opposite direction of Camille, keeping barely a few steps ahead of Michael's attacks. Most of them struck the ground uselessly, but one particular blast seemed to stop in mid-air only a few yards away from Michael. It formed into an ice encasement and hung there, swaying gently from side to side. It only took that long for Vince to understand.

“Britney is here! Stall her, Camille!”

Camille hurtled forward, coming to a stop with the hovering ice at her front and flag at her back.

“Well, since my cover is blown, do you mind freezing the healer so I can grab the flag?” Britney’s voice posed the query from near Michael.

In response Michael turned to the sound and let fly two quick blasts to the ground. New mini-glaciers formed, these seeming as though a set of legs were bound in them.

“What the hell!?!” Britney screamed, shimmering into view. She was clearly stuck in place, rooted to the ground by her ally.

“If you grab the flag it’s over,” Michael said flatly. “I’m not letting anyone interrupt this.”

“You are out of your fucking mind,” Britney said, not in shock or outrage, but in a slow, fearful acceptance.

“You’re the one who made the deal,” Michael reminded her. He turned back to Vince and began slowly advancing. “Now, let’s pick this back up. I hope you can put up a better fight than your last friend. He was pathetic.”

“So Alex did catch up to you,” Vince said, trying to keep himself calm. There were rules to this test, people watching. Michael couldn’t have done anything too bad.

“Be careful, Vince,” Britney called, all semblance of camaraderie abandoned. “He’s not stable. He beat Alex half to death.”

“Is that true?” Vince asked as the distance between him and Michael grew smaller and smaller.

“Not my fault he can’t take a punch. Kind of reminds me of you. Maybe when we’re done here I’ll go back and see if he’s awake. Or I can work out the rest of my energy on your little friend by the flag,” Michael said. His face was hidden behind the ice, but the madness of his voice made it clear that the unseen smile had gone from merely flirting with derangement to a full-blown grope fest.

“I see.” If some of the other Melbrook residents had been there, they would have recognized that tone. It was the voice that had come from Vince when he dealt with George last year. It was a vocal vibration that marked the



end of his seemingly infinite patience and kindness. It was a set of harmonic undulations that broadcast a single message with crisp efficiency: Vince was pissed, and that did not bode well for those who had brought him to this point.

Michael didn't notice any of this, however. He was too busy sending multiple bursts of freezing energy toward Vince at very short range. To his mild surprise, his opponent didn't even try to dodge. Instead Vince stood there as the forming ice engulfed him, sealing him from head to toe in a solid block within the span of a few seconds. There was the series of small pops and crackles as the frozen jail finished growing, and then a brief silence descended over the field.

"Anticlimactic, but I guess that's the best I can expect from you," Michael chuckled, turning around and looking to Camille, his last remaining opponent on the field.

47.

“Aren’t you curious how the fight is going?” Mary asked as she and Nick trudged through the grass, the taller boy finally able to shamble along under his own power.

“Nah. It’s Vince and Camille versus Britney and Michael. There are only two ways it can go. Either Britney sneaks past and grabs the flag, or they manage to stall and incapacitate her.”

“And what about Michael?”

Nick snorted. “Come on, you know why I paired up Vince with Camille.”

“Because they represented both combat and non-combat abilities of high level,” Mary said. “Also because she’s in love with him, so I’m guessing that will make her work harder to help him.”

“True, but there’s another reason. Camille is small statured, soft-spoken, kind, and gentle. Her only ability is to heal people and make them feel better. She comes off so decent even I want to feel protective of her, and I don’t really go in for any of that shit. Now, given that we know Vince is the kind of guy who only goes all out when other people are in danger, how hard do you think he’ll fight to keep someone like her safe?”

“Oh, yeah, that won’t be pretty,” Mary concurred.

“I don’t know about that,” Nick said. “I’d put down my money that before that fight is over there will be some truly stupendous fireworks.”

\* \* \*

The thunderous cracking sound filled the field before Michael had made it more than two steps away. He turned around in time to see the ice splintering to the ground, falling away from Vince in rivers of steam and boiling water. The silver-haired boy stepped forth from his former frosty tomb without any overt effort. His blue eyes were locked on Michael, unwavering as he left the collapsing remains in his shadow.

“Guess I shouldn’t be surprised you keep a little more heat in you after our last fight. I wonder how many times you can pull that trick,” Michael taunted.

“Do you know why I told you this was pointless?” Vince asked calmly.

“Yeah, you didn’t want me to beat the hell out of you,” Michael said, attacking with two more bolts. Vince caught both of them on his forearm, but this time the ice began to destruct as soon as it formed. Michael sucked in a breath of surprise. This didn’t seem to be taxing Vince nearly as much as it should have.

“You can’t freeze me anymore,” Vince told him. “No matter what you throw, I can melt through it.”

“Fine, I’ll just kick your ass the old-fashioned way,” Michael declared, charging forward. He opened with a combo of rights and a left hook designed to take Vince’s head clean from his shoulders. The freak might be able to break out of ice, but a fist wrapped in a few inches of it would still crunch his bones. At least, it would have if it connected. Instead, Vince moved around his punches easily, not even bothering to deflect, merely stepping aside as if to imply they weren’t worth the bother.

“You were already a worse fighter than I am. You might have structured your shell to let you move, but it still slows you down. You’re no threat to me physically, either.”

Something about that freak’s voice was really raising Michael’s ire. It was so distant, so unengaged. Like he really didn’t even care. Like Michael wasn’t worth his precious fucking effort. Adrenaline and rage roared through Michael’s veins. Who did this little pip-fuck think he was?

“Kiss my ass!” Michael screamed, striking faster and more violently. His fists kept connecting with nothing but air while Vince’s smug expression stayed out of reach. Michael doubled his effort, his joints screaming in their sockets as he pushed them to their limits. “You’ll tire out eventually, and you can’t even hurt me! My win is inevitable!”

Vince wove through his latest attacks and emerged several feet away. Michael paused to catch his breath, eyes never leaving his prey as he readied his body for the next flurry.

“Where did you get the idea that I couldn’t hurt you?” Vince asked offhandedly. Michael braced himself for the torrent of flame and heat. If he could keep his armor regenerating faster than Vince could pour on the damage, Michael was certain he could run out his enemy’s reserves. This was what he’d been working toward. Once the absorber was empty, he’d be as

helpless as always. All Michael had to do was outlast his fire.

So it was that when the lightning erupted from Vince's palm and struck Michael's torso there was both a literal and emotional shock ripping through his system. His legs collapsed out from under him and he fell to the ground, muscles twitching but still conscious.

"When did... electricity..." Michael was barely able to talk. His throat felt ragged and he couldn't seem to focus. He was vaguely aware that the attack had damaged his armor, but repairing it was beyond his capacity at the moment. It took all of his effort just to pull himself up to his knees and look upon his opponent.

"The reason I told you this was pointless is because it is," Vince said, staring down at Michael as his defense slid away in jagged, icy chunks. "You can't freeze me. You can't hit me. You can't even defend against me. You're so far below me that beating you isn't even a challenge. You're nothing to me, Michael."

It couldn't be true. He was just a freak. He'd gotten in a lucky punch on their first day. All the attention he'd gotten, all the friendships he'd managed, all the reputation he'd accrued, it had all been a mistake. It had been unwarranted. Michael was the great one. Michael was the one people were supposed to admire, like they had before he got to Lander. He was going to prove it, prove it by soaking his knuckles in Vince's blood. So why was he the one on the ground? Why wouldn't his brain come together and let him function?

"Normally I wouldn't have been so cruel as to show you this bit of truth, but you just wouldn't let it go. So try and learn the lesson this time, Michael, and keep it at the forefront of your mind. Because if you ever threaten or touch my goddamned friends again, I'll show you what I can really do." Vince turned around and walked away from Michael's still struggling body.

"You didn't knock me out," Michael called, his muddled mind finally forming words.

"I know. Why would I bother? It isn't as if you can do anything."

Those words, and the truth behind them, savaged Michael more than any of Vince's attacks. Britney could see the devastation in her teammate's face even as Vince walked toward her. It was strange; given what she'd just seen she should be afraid. After all, he still had to incapacitate her. The fear

wouldn't come; whether it was because she just didn't see Vince being unnecessarily mean or because she was just too drained to conjure any more emotions, it wasn't there. As it turned out, there was no need for it anyway.

“Attention all students!” Dean Blaine’s voice seemed to echo from all around them, broadcasting from the sky itself. “The match between Teams One and Four has reached its end. Alice Adair of Team One has taken Team Four’s flag. Staff will be coming through for healing and extraction momentarily.”

## 48.

“How are you feeling?” Professor Pendleton asked.

“I’ve got one of the best healers in the school on my team; she patched me up right away,” Nick reminded him. The two were in an infirmary office going over a post battle check-up. Healers or not, it would be irresponsible not to check a student’s mental and physical health after any combat situation. The professors handled this task not because of any extensive medical knowledge but because they knew all too well the tell-tale signs of a student hiding something that might be wearing on them. Such was not the case today, as Nick was in rather high spirits.

“Still, electricity can have some lingering effects. Tasing yourself was pretty dangerous.”

“Not like it’s my first time on the shit end of an electrical charge. Besides, you only call something dangerous if it fails. When it succeeds, it’s called ‘innovative.’”

Professor Pendleton suppressed a sigh. He wondered if he’d been this foolhardy and brash in his youth. Had any of his own instructors been present, they would have happily informed him that this young man in sunglasses had nothing on him in the way of moronic stunts. As it was, Professor Pendleton merely continued with the exam.

“I suppose it was rather creative. I guess no one would have expected you to get the better of Gilbert in a one on one match.”

“Yeah; in fairness, even I was only giving myself fifty percent odds.”

“Yet you went ahead with such an uncertain strategy. Why?”

“Because I’ll take fifty percent over zero,” Nick said simply.

“There was another option. You could have let Mary handle both of them,” Professor Pendleton pointed out.

“Gilbert’s power makes him difficult for her to deal with. We fought him last year and found that out firsthand. If he’d been distracting enough, Terrance might have gotten in a fluke shot.”

“Why, Nick, you almost sound as though you were concerned about her.”

“I was. Mary is our strongest member; if she got taken out it could have spelled a lot of trouble.”

“A rather cold, if accurate, sentiment. At any rate, it’s hard to argue tactics with the one who triumphed,” Professor Pendleton said. He pulled out a folder from his briefcase and set it in Nick’s lap. “You’re free to go. Consider this a parting gift. It’s a summation of what happened with each member of your team during the match. Normally it would go to the captain, but since you’re here and I have it, you can pass it along.”

“I guess handing these out is standard?”

“Only to the teams themselves. If you want to know about the others, you’ll have to rely on gossip and hearsay like everyone else,” Professor Pendleton said, his words half statement and half challenge.

“So we don’t get to know anything about the other teams’ match then?”

“Only their completion time. Yours, by the way, was forty-four minutes and thirteen seconds,” Professor Pendleton told him. “As for the other match, Team Two defeated Team Three in just a hair under ten.”

“That’s actually better than I’d hoped,” Nick said, his face void of the surprise one might have expected.

“You do understand that they devastated the other team in a fourth of the time it took you to win, right?”

“Sure, but look at what they were working with. Taking ten minutes to win tells me they don’t have a strong enough team dynamic or tactician,” Nick surmised, rising to his feet.

“Just out of curiosity, what do you base that conclusion on?”

“The fact that if I’d run their team, they could have won the match in five.”

Professor Pendleton started to chide him then thought better of it. Nick was many things: irritating, condescending, emotionally distant, all that had been made very obvious. He wasn’t overly prideful, however. The boy seemed to look at himself with an almost clinical detachment when evaluating his personal capabilities. From everything Professor Pendleton had seen, if Nick thought he could do something, he usually had several good reasons for it.

“You should be less concerned with how to manage them and more concerned with how to defeat them.”

“Oh, come on, you and I both know those are one and the same,” Nick replied, heading for the door. “Thanks for the file. I’ll be sure Mary gets it.”

Professor Pendleton suppressed a smile. Say what you would about the kid, he kept things interesting.

“Nice to see you’re taking this job at least somewhat seriously.” Professor Pendleton’s smile evaporated as he heard the voice from the doorway. He turned around merely to indicate he heard it; there was no need to verify its source. He knew that voice very, very well.

“Hello there, Professor Hill. All done checking on students?” Professor Pendleton asked stiffly.

“Professor Hill? Really, Sean, it is bad enough you avoid me at every turn, now you want to stick with formalities. I’m beginning to feel a bit hurt,” Professor Hill replied.

“My apologies, Blake. I suppose I just don’t think we have all that much to talk about.”

“I think we could talk about plenty. Why on earth you’ve come here, for example.”

“Dean Blaine requested I fill the vacant position, one that opened up because you allowed a pair of traitors to live under your nose for years,” Professor Pendleton snapped, his rigid tone caving to his impatience.

“So we replace traitors with a criminal. The Lander HCP is really moving up in the world.”

“If you have a problem with my employment, bring it up with the dean. Otherwise, we’re done here,” Professor Pendleton said, striding through the doorway. Professor Hill grabbed his arm before he could make it all the way past.

“Let go of me, Blake. You don’t want to do this.”

“We aren’t kids anymore, Sean, and I’ve gotten a lot stronger while you’ve been rotting in jail. Still, you’re right, I don’t want to do it. I just want to make you aware that I know the real reason you came to Lander.”

Professor Pendleton barked out a harsh laugh. “Congratulations, you



figured out the world's easiest puzzle. Of course she's why I'm here. What of it?"

"Just letting you know to watch yourself. That one's path has already been decided. Any attempts at interference will not be well-received."

"I wouldn't dream of it," Professor Pendleton lied. "Though given your track record with such things, maybe I should."

Professor Hill released Professor Pendleton's arm and lowered his voice. "What happened was a tragedy; I'll never disagree with you there. Placing blame doesn't help anyone."

"It might not, but it sure as hell helps me wake up in the morning," Professor Pendleton said fiercely, quickly walking away before his emotions could get the better of him.

## 49.

"I'd just like to start by saying that everyone did an amazing job," Mary began, standing in front of her team as they lounged in the Melbrook common room. "I was listening to the team's thoughts throughout the match and you all were great about staying with the plan and thinking ahead."

"Even Roy toed the line," Hershel agreed. The more muscular brother had opted not to attend the debrief meeting. Hershel suspected he was pouting at only getting one fight throughout the whole ordeal.

"He did indeed. In fact, it's thanks to him and Alice that we got the flag, so an extra kudos to them both," Mary continued.

Alice blushed as the room gently clapped for her and the absent warrior. It had been more luck than skill that she'd noticed a piece of fabric flapping in an artificial breeze; still, she was glad she'd finally contributed something to the team.

"Now then, because we only improve by learning from our mistakes and successes, Nick had a few things he wanted to address before we officially start celebrating our win," Mary said, sitting down.

"Thank you, Captain," Nick said with a flourishing bow. "First things first, I'd like to show you all a little motivation tool I've put together." He reached behind the couch and produced a rectangular black wooden frame. Within it were seven playing cards, each with the corresponding team member's name beneath it.

"Oh goody, the 'we suck' analogy has been framed," Alice said.

"Not exactly. You remember how I said I would update this as my data changed? Well, in light of today's match, I have a couple of alterations to make." Nick laid the frame on the couch and popped off the back. With surprising dexterity, he slipped away two of the cards and slid two more into their places. He refastened the back and held the frame up once more, turning it out for the room to see.

"I'm a queen now?" Vince asked uncertainly.

"I'd say adding electricity to your ranged arsenal more than qualifies you for that," Nick replied. "Incidentally, why is it you didn't mention that little development to any of us?"

“I don’t know. I mean, Professor Fletcher really put in a lot of work helping me learn it and it took a good while. I guess bringing it up felt like bragging,” Vince replied uncertainly.

“For reference, telling the people who coordinated strategies for the entire team that you have a new skill is very much not bragging: it is merely reporting information,” Nick assured him.

“So, Vince I get, but why is Camille now an ace?” Alex asked. “Wouldn’t that mean she had combat abilities?”

“Indeed she does,” Nick confirmed. His eyes happened over to the small girl, who at present looked as if she might faint. Had the file Professor Pendleton provided not included her explanation to Vince about her victory, Nick might have taken her reaction merely as embarrassment at the attention. As it was, he knew she was hiding her real power from Vince for some reason. Nick didn’t know why yet, but he would very soon. Until then, he saw no benefit in upsetting one of his new heavy hitters.

“It seems Camille has quite a martial arts background she neglected to mention to us. Given how well she held her own today, I felt the card change was appropriate,” Nick explained, taking an odd pleasure in watching the relief and shock wash over Camille’s face.

“That is awesome,” Hershel said. “You have to tell us about your fight.”

“I... um... I...” Camille stuttered weakly.

“She would never be so bold as to interrupt me during an official address,” Nick swooped in. “To continue, while we certainly had a lot of success today, I want to bring a very key piece of information to light. We damn near lost this match.”

“What do you mean? I thought everyone won their fights except Alex, who got double teamed,” Alice said, adding the last part in a bid to spare Alex’s ego.

“We did. We came out ahead in nearly every combat situation, but if it hadn’t been for a severe fuck-up on their team’s part, I doubt we’d be celebrating right now.”

“It’s true,” Vince agreed. “Britney was invisible when she and Michael came and attacked us. If he hadn’t gotten careless and frozen her

arm, we wouldn't have known she was there. Even with that, if he'd frozen Camille instead of his teammate, I'm not sure I could have kept her from getting to the flag in time."

"Precisely. I'm not saying this to point fingers or make anyone feel bad. You all did exactly what you were supposed to do. I just want you to be aware of the importance of keeping abreast of the enemy's tactics. Britney's plan removed a big part of our telepathic advantage, giving up combat losses to keep us occupied, and putting their faith in her securing the flag before we noticed she was there. It was risky as hell and it very nearly worked. We definitely earned this win, but by no means was it the blowout it might seem to be at a glance. Don't get overconfident, and don't underestimate our opponents. After this little upset, I don't expect them to be underestimating us."

"Wow, way to be a bummer," Alice said as silence descended.

"My apologies," Nick said with a fast grin. "Learning from both victory and failure is the only shot we have to make it through this thing."

"So what do we need to do?" Alex asked, his voice more eager than he meant it to be. Being the only one who lost today had left a bad taste in his mouth. He felt himself hungering to train and improve, never to be caught in such a humiliating defeat again.

"For tonight, we relax," Nick told him. "In the coming weeks we'll come up with some new training, but that's in the coming weeks. Today, we kicked ass, and I think we earned a night to take it easy. Maybe we'll even celebrate more enthusiastically this weekend. That's all up to you guys. As it stands, we're winners, and I think we should bask in the glow of being on top for a change."

The sentiment, even if not verbally articulated, was definitely exuberantly echoed throughout the room.

\* \* \*

"I want to thank you for bringing this to our attention, Miss Ferguson," Dean Blaine said gently. "I know it can't have been easy."

"After what happened today it would have been a lot harder to try and sleep at night if I hadn't told you," Britney replied. Her eyes had grown moist during their talk, however her voice had remained steady through the entire duration. Britney knew this had to be done, if it made her feel like a snitch or

like she was betraying an unspoken allegiance to her fellow students, that was irrelevant. This was the right thing to do.

Dean Blaine regarded her with a new measure of respect. Fighting clear cut bad guys was easy to get behind, mentally and morally. When the world was black and white you never had to worry about feeling conflicted. In situations like this, in contrast, where there were ample easier ways out, Britney had still taken the right path even though it would weaken her team. As an educator he wasn't supposed to play favorites with his students, yet all the same he found himself earnestly glad that someone like this was placing so well in all of her exams.

"I assure you that we will take appropriate measures. In fact, Michael was already under close watch, but having one of his own peers express such concerns certainly solidifies what we'd feared."

"I just don't want anyone to get hurt," Britney said. "We got lucky today. If Vince hadn't been so much stronger... let's just say I don't think Michael would have been nearly as gracious a winner."

"The safety of my students is paramount," Dean Blaine told her. "This will be dealt with. I promise you."

"Thank you," Britney said rising to leave.

"Please send in Professor Fletcher on your way out. He should be waiting outside the door," Dean Blaine requested. Britney nodded her agreement and stepped outside of his office. A few minutes later the older man walked in, taking the seat she'd been occupying seconds before.

"I'd hoped with a bit of a leash and some close monitoring he would straighten up," Dean Blaine said simply. "Since you're the teacher of his best subject, tell me your impressions."

"He's talented. If he weren't so angry all the time he could make some serious progress with an ability like his," Professor Fletcher said. "What is it about Vince that's got him so twisted up in knots?"

"Mr. Reynolds is only the most recent in Michael Clark's line of conquests. His record indicates that when he loses to someone, most importantly when he loses image, he becomes obsessed with utterly surpassing them," Dean Blaine explained. "It was actually a strike in his favor when applying, because up until his time at Lander that obsession manifested itself in tireless training and effort to surpass his rival. I daresay his recent

shift to the psychotic revolves around his inability to make any traction in beating Mr. Reynolds, as well as a downward slide into alcohol abuse.”

“He’s drinking that much?”

“I’ve had a few covert searches of his dorm room performed. Suffice it to say he is well beyond the limit of what a healthy liver can reasonably be expected to handle, even a college-aged one. I’ve sat him down and reached out to him in a few private meetings, however nothing seems to be getting through.”

“Then today he nearly scrambled up Alex’s brains,” Professor Fletcher said. “If he’d tried to throw one more punch I was going to have to stop the whole match and intervene.”

“You were watching it?”

“Of course.”

“And tell me Carl, with all your years of experience, what do you think?”

Professor Fletcher chose his next words carefully, all too aware that the future of the young man in question would hang on them. “He had a killing intent. I’ve seen that look in too many people’s faces not to recognize it. I don’t know if he’s aware of it himself, but he wanted to kill that telepath. Now just a desire doesn’t mean much on its own, some of the best Supers I know were ones who had to actively control themselves to keep from letting their darker urges get the better of them in battle. Not everyone is inherently perfect. Having a monster inside doesn’t automatically make you one, provided you have the discipline and self-awareness to keep it on a chain.”

“I would agree with you on all counts,” Dean Blaine said. “In some ways I prefer dealing with people whose darkness is more visible. It leads to less unfortunate surprises.” If his voice was a touch bitter, Professor Fletcher let it pass without comment. “The issue here is that I think Michael Clark lacks that chain, whether it is a result of the alcohol abuse or some yet undiagnosed psychosis. Regardless, he has shown himself to be an unacceptable threat to the other students.”

“So we boot him?”

“We could, however given his skills and violent tendencies I feel like it would merely be a matter of time before he wound up in prison for some

assault crime.”

“I suppose so, but what other options do you have?”

“There is one other way to go with it. What Michael needs is more discipline and focus than he is getting in his current environment. Obviously he won’t be making the cut for Hero, but before we resort to full expulsion, we could give him a semester or two at Lander’s east campus to get himself together,” Dean Blaine said.

“I wasn’t aware Lander had an east campus,” Professor Fletcher said.

“It’s closer to a sister school than anything else. We don’t talk about it often because we only send over students who require very special training or very strict discipline,” Dean Blaine explained.

“Sounds like a good fit for him then,” Professor Fletcher agreed. “What will you do if he doesn’t want to transfer?”

“I wasn’t planning on making it a request. Tonight Michael Clark will either be moved to Lander East or he will be booted and banned from the HCP program,” Dean Blaine replied without inflection. “I will not give training to a man who I believe will use it to harm others. Not now, not ever. Not in my school.”

“Understood,” Professor Fletcher said. He began to leave, then a rogue thought wandered through his mind. “If I remember right, you’re a Lander graduate yourself. Ever do any time at the east campus during your days here?”

Dean Blaine turned away from his employee so Carl wouldn’t be able to see the ever so slight grin trying to break through his professional demeanor. “That will be all, Professor Fletcher.”

## 50.

“So how does it feel, oh valiant captain, to have won your first match?” Hershel asked as Mary laid her head on his chest. They were in Hershel’s room, the night of communal happiness having wound down some time ago. It was a moment of coupleness, the likes of which had become increasingly rare with all the preparations and training as of late.

“Exhausting,” Mary replied. “Trying to keep up with what everyone was doing across the entire battlefield, not to mention worrying about them when things got dangerous, and having to listen to Nick all day wore me out. I’m going to sleep like a baby tonight.”

“I bet. You’re quite an amazing girl, you know that?”

“It might have come up in conversation a few times,” Mary said, her tone playful but her smile genuine. “You’re not too shabby yourself.”

“Meh, I’m a nerd who can turn into someone awesome. That makes me less interesting and more a homework jockey for my alter ego.”

“None of that,” Mary said, lifting her head so she could look him in the eye. “You’re brave, smart, resourceful, and kind. I wouldn’t be the girlfriend of a guy who was just ‘meh’, after all.”

“You make a strong case,” Hershel said. He leaned forward and kissed her on the cheek, bringing her back down against his chest so they could lie comfortably. “On the subject of resourcefulness, I had a thought about how we could celebrate. Halloween is next weekend, so-”

“Please don’t say you want to go to that giant frat costume party again.”

“Perish the thought. I was thinking we could hit one of the giant haunted houses in town. There’s one called Screamtoria that’s apparently known nationally. It has mazes, hidden passages, and all sort of special effects. They say they even use a Super or two to really bring the impossible to life. Plus, on Halloween weekend they have a big lounge running at the end where you can hang out and drink or just breeze through. I figure that way it can be scary or drunken depending on what each person wants.”

“Plus you’re hoping to have me clutched against you in fear for the duration of it,” Mary pointed out.



“I thought you didn’t listen to my thoughts?”

“Didn’t need to. I’m hoping for the same thing.” Mary reached up and kissed him, this one definitely not on the cheek. Though there were many physical boundaries the couple had yet to cross, they still kissed with enough passion that by the end, neither one was thinking about haunted houses.

\* \* \*

Camille was nearly halfway back to her dorm when the figure stepped out of the shadows. She tensed immediately, turning sideways and bringing up her hands in a defensive stance. It laughed at her, and at the sound Camille knew she wasn’t in danger. She was still a bit annoyed at the entrance, however.

“You scared me,” Camille said, relaxing her body.

“I scared you? That’s pretty rich given the difference between us,” Nick said, walking all the way into the light. It was hard to see through his sunglasses at night, but after over a year of wearing them he’d gotten plenty of practice. “Seriously, after what I learned today, it’s hard for me to imagine you really being scared of anyone.”

“I don’t like being startled.”

“You don’t? Funny coincidence, I’m not big on surprises either. So try and imagine my displeasure at finding out one of my teammates had been hiding a tremendously important aspect of her powers.”

“I wasn’t trying to hide, I just didn’t want-”

“Vince to know. Yes, I’m aware of your feelings, as is Mary, as is really anyone with perception. You’re in luck, because that criteria still rules out Vince. I get that you are keeping it from him, and it doesn’t bother me. What does is when you hide things I need to know about in order to effectively strategize against our opponents. So let’s go ahead and clear the air. First off, why are you so set against him knowing you can give back the damage you absorb?”

“I... we met when we were kids. He doesn’t remember me because I was using a nickname, had dyed my hair, and told him how I absorbed damage instead of making him think I was a healer. I’m scared if he sees my real power he’ll figure out who I am.”

“Why is that so bad? Did the childhood version of you beat him up or

something?”

“No. I was his first kiss,” Camille said, unable and unwilling to hide the blush washing over her skin. She expected a snappy comeback, but Nick was silent for some time before responding. When he finally did, his voice was softer and more amiable.

“I get it. I didn’t understand the little monologue you gave Allen at first, but now it makes sense. Vince must have left quite an impression on you as a kid. Not that surprising, I doubt he was any less foolhardy and moral then than he is now. So you met this kid whose memory stuck with you, and then some years later you show up at Lander and here he is. Now you’ve finally got your chance to be with him, as long as you can find the right angle of approach.”

“It isn’t like that!” Camille protested, her voice rising despite herself. “I don’t expect him to be with me, and I’m not trying to trick him into it. It’s just that he’s... he’s so reckless. He always charges into things for other people without giving any thought to his own safety. One day he’s going to get seriously hurt doing that.”

“And you want to be there to save him when he does,” Nick finished. “Which you have a much better chance of doing as a friend than as a romantic partner. After all, statistically speaking, most relationships fall apart. I think I finally comprehend. All right then, I’ll keep your secret for now.”

“You will?”

“Yes, but understand, keeping it should never take priority over winning in one of our team’s matches. Got me?”

“Of course.”

“Then I don’t see any harm in letting you have your privacy,” Nick told her. “It’s kind of a shame, actually.”

“How so?”

“You’re selfless, protective, and dedicated. If you weren’t so set against getting involved with him, you two would be a good match for each other. Probably better for me in the long run this way. The last thing I need is a pair of you do-gooders always around. Just handling one unwavering moral compass takes enough energy.”

“Thank you, I think.”

“Not at all,” Nick said, giving her a smile that made Camille think of when her cat used to watch the fish swim in their bowl. “I’m glad we had this little chat. I think our team will be stronger for it. Be safe walking home. You never know what weirdoes are out there.” With those words and a wave, Nick headed back to Melbrook. Camille, meanwhile, started back toward her own dorm, trying with little success to reassure herself that Nick would be true to his word and keep her secret. She should have known better than to worry: Nick Campbell would never betray someone’s confidence.

Unless, of course, there was something to be gained from it.

## 51.

Tuesday morning found the sophomore students shuffling uncertainly to their first classes after gym. It was strange to shift gears so rapidly. Yesterday they'd been looking at each other with the savagery only competition can bring out, but today they were back in their normal schedules and social groups. It was uncomfortable to greet a friend that one might have had to punch in the face yesterday as if nothing had ever happened. The professors never said it out loud, but this flexibility of perspective was as much a point of the exercises as learning the initial teamwork. It was an unfortunate and undeniable fact that in the world of Heroes, sometimes you found yourself fighting a friend. Getting accustomed to it now reduced hesitation down the line.

The students soon fell back into their routine with minimal effort. It helped that the professors acted as though Monday had never happened, moving right from Friday's lesson on to the logical continuation. There was no gain to be had in rehashing the matches; everyone knew who had won and who had lost. If the teams wanted consultation on why those results had been produced then they could schedule office hours. For the most part the goal was to move everyone past this last trial and get them refocused so they'd be ready for the next one. Besides, as the chilly October air suggested, it was growing later in the year. That meant midterms were fewer than eight weeks away. That thought alone was enough to put more fear in the students than any ghost or goblin. Of course, some people had other concerns on their minds.

"Hey, tall, tan, and talkative," Angela yelled, grabbing Thomas's attention as the sophomores headed toward the lifts. "Hold up for a moment, I need to chat with you."

Thomas paused in his walking; HCP classes were over and he had some time before his first afternoon class, so it would be fine to listen to her. He motioned for Violet and Stella to keep going. The three of them usually had lunch together; he knew their habits and catching up would be no problem.

"How can I help you?" Thomas said politely as Angela approached.

"We need to talk about the party."

“The party?”

“Yeah, the party. The shindig, the festivity, the kegger, the gathering. That enough synonyms?” Angela asked.

“I know what a party is; I’m not sure which party you’re talking about.”

“Look, October is winding down. That means pretty soon most of the cuts on the freshman class will have been made,” Angela said impatiently. “And as I explained last year when you came to the party at my place, it is tradition for the sophomores to extend an invitation to a social gathering for those newbies still remaining.”

“Wait, you want me to throw it?”

“Good thing you’ve got a knack for fighting, kid, you aren’t too quick on the mental upswing. Yes, you need to throw it. You’re a sophomore and you have one of the few houses with adequate size, location, and residents that are all Supers.”

Thomas resisted the urge to ask how she knew so much about his living space: a girl this determined probably had methods he was happier being ignorant of. Instead he focused on diffusing the situation. “I might have the means; however, I’m not really the most gregarious person in our class. Perhaps there is a better fit for this duty.”

“You’re joking, right? Look, being a good host in this situation isn’t about creating fun. The kegs and attendees will handle that all on their own. No, it’s about being respected and powerful enough to impose order when things get out of hand, which they will. Take last year, for example; if I hadn’t broken up the pissing match that started over beer pong, a lot of bad shit could have happened.”

“If it’s power and respect, why not someone like Chad? I doubt anyone would question his authority to impose peace.”

“For one thing, because he lives in the dorms and doesn’t have a place. For another, because Chad, while hunky, is pretty anti-social. I don’t know how many people would show to something he organized. Having a good number of sophomore attendees makes the freshmen feel like they’ve walked into part of an existing community. If the party consists of five people, they’ll feel like they’re courted by a fringe of losers who can’t make friends with their own class.”

“I suppose I can see the point there,” Thomas conceded. “I still have some-”

“Listen, I don’t have time for this,” Angela cut him off. “The torch is passed, you have been tasked. If you want help and advice, by all means come to me. If you want to slide the burden to someone else, that’s your call. Just remember, we have this tradition for a reason. Freshman year is scary as shit, and letting those kids know that they have some support coming from higher up the ladder can make a big difference for some of them. So if you want to blow it off, I can’t stop you. Then again, if I thought you were the type to do that, I wouldn’t be having this talk with you in the first place.” Angela turned and began to walk away.

“You don’t know me beyond a few times we’ve briefly spoken,” Thomas called after her, his words bouncing in the now empty hall. “What makes you think I’m a good fit for this?”

“Shane recommended you,” Angela replied, turning around and giving Thomas a half-smile. “Funny thing about that kid, he has an odd knack for getting a sense of people. He said you were the most responsible guy in the whole class. That was enough for me.”

Thomas took a breath and cleared his head as Angela’s sunshine-colored locks swayed off in the opposite direction. He really didn’t want to throw a party, especially not with kegs and drinking and the like. It would be a large inconvenience for him and his roommates. Despite his wants, however, it seemed this was a duty, and Thomas Castillo had a very firm understanding of duty. He set his resolve and began heading toward the lifts.

On the upside, at least Violet and Stella would be happy about the news.

## 52.

"I don't understand why I can't just be a knight again," Vince protested as he stared at the racks of colorful ensembles arranged along the walls.

"Because Halloween is a chance to have a little image experimentation, and doing the same costume over and over is not an acceptable social practice," Nick explained. "Plus, shopping for them is half the fun."

"You have an odd idea of fun," Vince said with little conviction. He'd already given up and resolved himself to this fate; he was merely making sure to officially log his protests on the way down.

"Look at it this way: if you don't dress up then you'll stand out at Screamtopia. We're supposed to blend in," Hershel pointed out.

"Which I could do in the knight outfit I already own."

"You just don't get it, Vince," Nick said, turning his own attention back to costume selection. The three boys were at a party supply store that was decked out in appropriate Halloween decor. After some discussion, Hershel's haunted house suggestion had won out for their October 31 plans. Team One would all be going in a few days along with Thomas, Stella, Violet, Will, and anyone else they opted to bring along. The girls had gone on a shopping trip, leaving the three boys to their own devices. This had culminated in procrastination, leading them to search the already-scoured store with mere days to the deadline.

"What about condiments?" Hershel suggested. "They have ketchup, mayo, and mustard costumes."

"There are two problems with that. First, we'd look ridiculous. Second, we aren't a trio of gay polygamists, so we don't need to be dressing in theme," Nick said.

"A 'no' probably would have conveyed that just as well," Vince scolded.

"Sorry, my bad," Nick said offhandedly. "Let's think in terms of things that work well for us personally rather than as a team. Hershel, how do you feel about mummies?"

“Ambivalent.”

“Good enough.” Nick snatched up a mummy costume and held it out to the huskier member of the party. “Go grab a dressing room.”

“Why a mummy?”

“Because Jekyll and Hyde would be too obvious. Just go see if you like it.”

Hershel began to protest more, then realized he didn’t have any ideas for costumes better than the one in his hand and decided to at least see how it looked.

“Okay, that’s one down; now what to do you about you, Silver? If we play to your hair color we could do a rave druggie or an old man. Any preference?”

“Neither,” Vince replied quickly. He’d just seen how being noncommittal had played out for Hershel so he was making his opinions known.

“Fine, fine. So picky for someone who says he doesn’t care.” Nick kept scanning the racks, looking for anything that would provide a ready-made explanation for Vince’s hair. On campus it didn’t stand out too much: there were plenty of people with unnatural hair colorings walking the Lander campus. Screamtopia was different, it wasn’t associated with the school, so they needed to try and look as normal as possible under the circumstances.

“How about a ghost? We get you some white clothing, dust you up with baby powder, and you make some moaning noises on cue.”

“Maybe,” Vince said cautiously. “Hey, what about this one? It seems kind of appropriate when you think about it.”

Nick glanced at the costume clutched in his friend’s hand. It was appropriate - a little too appropriate, actually - but it could account for the silver hair under the right circumstances.

“Try it on. If it fits we’ll grab some accessories and call you done.”

“Cool.” Vince headed off toward the line at the dressing room, leaving Nick to dig through the racks for his own holiday-appropriate attire. Last year’s gunslinger had been fun, but this year Nick was feeling a bit more mischievous, like he wanted one that showed a touch of his own personality.



He ran his hands through the patterns of cheap fabric one by one, dismissing each as he passed it by.

Nick found the right costume near the end of the store, just when he was resolving himself to pick something that fit rather than something he liked. He'd seen variations of this idea already, but something about this particular one called to him. He snatched it up and made a beeline for the dressing room. There was no question he was buying it; all that remained to be seen was if it would require alteration.

\* \* \*

Chad was already in the gym when Shane walked in. He ignored the blonde's presence and went over to the free weights, trying to seem indifferent. Of course Chad was already here; Chad was always here, always working on getting better. Not that he needed it.

The two boys were the only sophomores here today; most of the others had been taking a break since the test. Some were feeling smug, some were licking their wounds, and some were just too tired to put in the extra hours. Shane finished a round of curls and moved to the bench press. He was halfway through his first set when a familiar shadow fell across his face.

"Need a spotter?"

Shane checked the venomous retort that wanted to fly out of his mouth. He had to get himself under control. He'd always known Chad was stronger than him; that wasn't new. His team being so thoroughly trashed had still left a sour flavor in his mouth, and he hadn't quite been able to curb the bubbling anger directed toward his friend. In truth, that was the reason he'd been avoiding him; he didn't want to say anything that would leave a lasting tarnish between them over something as ultimately trivial as a Capture the Flag match.

"Sure." Shane kept the bar moving, pushing himself beyond where he would have stopped had a safety net not been present. In the end, he didn't end up needing Chad's help. His friend stayed silently present the whole time, waiting just in case. Shane set the bar down and grabbed his water bottle to take a drink.

"Haven't seen you around much," Chad said. Something seemed different about him today. It took a few seconds for Shane to realize it, but Chad was awkward. It was something Shane had never seen before. Usually the boy was so self-possessed and determined that everything he did exuded

confidence. Not right now. No, at the moment he looked like a trout trying to blend in at a hammerhead convention.

“Been sort of busy studying for midterms,” Shane lied.

“Oh yeah, that makes sense.” Chad didn’t have to study for finals. His power allowed him to keep his brain in peak efficiency, resulting in perfect recall of anything he’d read or seen when he needed it. Cramming for tests was just one of those million little inconveniences he didn’t understand. “Doing anything for Halloween?”

“I think my team wanted to hit up the frat party they throw every year,” Shane said.

“Sounds fun. Mine is going to that haunted house downtown.”

“You going to join them?”

“Not sure yet,” Chad said.

“You should. Party nights are a good chance to build team spirit.”

“I’ll keep that in mind. Um, so I was kind of wanting to check something with you. It might sound stupid but we’re okay, right?” Chad asked, his eyes staring intently at the weight bar.

“You don’t have a lot of practice with friends, do you?”

“Not really.”

Shane took another sip of water. It was almost unnerving to see Chad like this. Still, it was helping to diffuse the remaining anger from Shane’s defeat. Staying mad at him in this state felt like being mad at a puppy three days after it peed on the floor.

“We’re fine,” Shane said. “I just needed a little time to let my pride heal. You trounced us pretty well.”

“Maybe,” Chad said. “You should be aware, if we’d faced any other team we would have won in half the time. You guys put up a hell of a fight.”

“We did our best. You want to go grab some dinner after we finish down here?” Shane asked, extending an olive branch of his own.

Chad nodded. “Let’s run a few laps and get some grub.”

## 53.

To call Screamtoria a building would be akin to calling quantum physics mildly complicated. It was a compound, a series of warehouses that had been built upon and interjoined many years previous. After the original owner's company collapsed, a few men with vision (as well as stolen plans and financial records from other haunted houses) saw what it could become and made the necessary alterations. Now it stood as a mecca for the Halloween devotees in California, people driving for hours to wander through its eerily enchanted hallways and yelp in terror. It wasn't just the leaping actors that made it a special kind of scary; Screamtoria worked hard to create an entire atmosphere of fear. Visitors were allowed to come through in carefully limited groups so that they experienced a sense of isolation, a few Supers were kept on staff to bend the limits of what was and wasn't possible in key areas, and of course there was the maze.

"Thews a mwaze?"

"For the love of god, man, give it up," Nick said. All of Team One was walking through the parking lot, trying not to be intimidated by the daunting line jutting out from the surprisingly well-lit building. The seven students were in anything but normal garb, each costumed into a Halloween persona, some closer to the truth than others.

"Sahwy," Vince replied, awkwardly spitting the plastic fangs into his hand. He wore a black cape and faux crushed velvet vest. His normally disheveled hair was slicked back, and a cheap plastic necklace hung around his neck. Even without the fangs he was easily recognizable as a classic vampire.

"To answer your question, yeah, the maze is a big part of the appeal here. It runs across a few floors of the complex, and there are tons of routes that force you to split up. All of them eventually lead to the end, but the first one of a group to finish it gets a free drink at the lounge," explained Hershel the prisoner. The mummy costume had been a bust, and eventually he'd settled on a simple orange jumpsuit prisoner costume. It wasn't terribly exciting, but it was functional and easy to move in, which was really all Hershel wanted. He usually got his fill of costumes from LARPing; for Hershel, Halloween was about the mystical sense of fear.

"Not that we can drink anyway," Princess Mary pointed out. She wore

a purple dress that trailed the ground and a glittery tiara in her hair. “This is a respectable business, not a frat party with lax rules.”

“If I’ve learned one thing about this town, it’s that the local population has the resourcefulness of black ops agents when it comes to finding ways to drink,” Alice the devil observed. She wore a tight pair of black leather pants and a black corset, pressing her noticeable chest upward. It was a corset with shoulders, and one that still left plenty to the imagination. Alice might be breaking out of her protected shell, but her risqué limit was still well below others her age. Atop her head was a pair of red horns that almost seemed natural, her voluminous locks hiding the string that held them in place.

Camille could have pointed out that such a thing could be said of college students anywhere, but as usual she stayed silent. Her own costume was a pair of green scrubs and a white lab coat. There had been a stethoscope as part of the costume too, but she’d left it in her dorm rather than keep up with it all night. In truth, she wasn’t much of a fan of haunted houses, and had Stella and Violet not forced her to come, she doubted she would have left home. They were going to the frat party with their team, yet the two girls had been relentless in pressuring Camille to join in her group’s festivities. She craned her head, wishing she were taller so she could see her friends amidst the crowd. Her team was supposed to meet Will, Jill, and Selena near the entrance so they could all go in together.

“In that spirit, my flask is more than decorative,” Nick said, his hand briefly touching the wooden gourd that hung on his hip next to his fake sword. He wore a flowing white shirt, black pants, and a pair of cuffed boots that were basic, but the coat and all of its buttons and pockets really brought the costume together. A few accessories such as a bandanna and the flask had been added for flair; however, they were hardly necessary. Even with the sunglasses Nick couldn’t have been mistaken for anything but a pirate.

“Why am I not surprised?” Mary sighed. Ye gods, she really did feel like the mom of this group, and they were far from easy to parent.

“I don’t see any of the others,” Vince said, craning around. “What are they dressed as?”

“Jill is an Amazonian and Selena is a pimp. I don’t think Will was going to wear a costume,” Alex supplied.

“I don’t suppose you can pick them out of the crowd?” Hershel asked Mary.

“You’re kidding, right? With this many people, this amped up, it’s like trying to hear one voice at a concert.”

“Just asking,” Hershel said.

“No worries, I found them,” Alex said. He was, surprisingly, not doing an encore of last year’s Jedi costume. Instead he wore a red shirt with the Federation insignia stitched on it.

Mary gave him a speculative look. She knew he wasn’t lying, he didn’t have any reason to do so in a situation like this, but she wasn’t sure how it was possible he’d singled out those minds so easily. Mary had at first thought that she and Alex merely had different talents in different areas, but she was increasingly beginning to suspect their abilities worked in fundamentally different ways. It would be impossible to confirm so it was ultimately pointless, yet still it nagged at her every now and then.

“Hey, guys,” Vince hollered, waving at the familiar forms as they came into view. His hand stopped abruptly and fell to his side. It didn’t take long for the others to see why. It seemed Selena, Will, and Jill had brought the others from Team Two with them. Standing there, looking equally unsure about how they would get through this line, were Chad, Julia, Rich, and the reason Vince’s hand had dropped like an anchor: Sasha.

Vince wondered if it was too late to make a run for the car.

## 54.

Screamtopia was proving to be as efficient as it was scary, which was very. A zombie guide led them through twisting halls with gaps that often held monsters waiting to leap out and just as often did not. It made the shocks harder to anticipate and that made them all the more effective. The rooms themselves were decorated terror scenes; every prop and every costume spared no detail to craft an atmosphere of unapologetic horror. The walls echoed with yelps and even a few genuine screams.

The HCP students, beings who in the back of their minds thought themselves combat-hardened warriors already, found themselves just as prone to bouts of fright as humans while they trod the bleary black halls. So dark was the building between rooms that one had to navigate half by touch, and even the usually unflappable Nick had to remove his sunglasses after his first several stumbles. It was a fun time overall; the telepaths even suspended their listening to better immerse themselves in the spirit of fear. The one potential blowup had been avoided so far, with neither Sasha nor Vince acknowledging each other and instead merely moving at opposite ends of the group. Likely they would have made it the whole night without so much as having to say “hi” if it hadn’t been for the maze. Then again, many things wouldn’t have happened that night if not for the maze.

“We have reached our parting point,” their zombie guide, Rathstein, instructed as they entered a room with five doors facing them. “I am no longer able to accompany you, for the magic that animates my putrid body will not sustain inside the Ghoul’s Labyrinth.”

His group glanced at each other excitedly. The kids always looked forward to the maze part; it was what made this haunted house truly unique. This was a bigger group than they usually took at any given time, but they’d been respectful and quiet during his speeches and spiels designed to set the mood. At this point, size didn’t matter anymore. No matter how big a group came through, the maze would see to it that every one of them felt the chill of death along their spine.

“Some parting words before you go: you may choose any door you wish and go through in whatever combinations you like. But be warned, the Ghoul’s Labyrinth is the only one who will decide your destination. Should you survive to the other side, you will find an oasis of relief waiting. For

those of you who don't... my corpsely comrades and I look forward to you joining our ranks."

With that, Rathstein stepped to the side of the wall and fell silent. His eyes shut and he leaned against the wall, truly appearing to be a dead body propped up and forgotten by some killer or gravedigger with a presumably hectic schedule.

It was, predictably, Chad who went first. Without comment he stepped to the first door and pulled it open. Waiting on the other side was an inky blackness that obscured what lay beyond, even to his enhanced vision.

"Anyone coming along?" Chad asked with a glance tossed over his shoulder. Will, Jill, and Rich walked over to join him. They filed through the opening one by one, and as the last one cleared the threshold, the door slammed forcefully shut, making the remaining people in the room jump a foot or so in the air.

When their hearts had slowed from thunderous pounding to a dull thudding, more groups split off through the doors. Alex and Selena took off through one opposite of Chad's exit point, Sasha and Julia scampered off through one of the diagonal ones, and Hershel and Mary took the other.

"Guess that leaves the lonely hearts club with the center door," Nick commented once Hershel and Mary were gone from the room. After the initial exodus and the couples pairing off, the only people left were himself, Vince, Alice, and Camille.

"Oh joy," Alice mumbled. Her words and tone were disappointed, even as her body language told a different story.

"Well, let's get to it; I don't want to fall too far behind," Vince said, striding forward and opening the door. He plunged through without hesitation, Nick hot on his heels, followed by Camille and Alice.

Their door slammed shut like all the others and Rathstein opened his eyes. He let out a sigh of relief at their exit; holding the corpse look took a lot of concentration. He wouldn't have minded keeping his eyes open a bit longer, too; there had been several major hotties in that group. Most of them were spoken for, as usual, but he was pretty sure the devil girl hadn't been leaping into anyone's arms as they sashayed through the haunted house. Part of him was tempted to see if they lingered in the lounge once his shift was over; at that point staff was allowed to join the party. He doubted he would: it was unlikely no one in that whole group had the hots for her and all but one of

the guys had been in almost strangely good shape. It was sort of weird to have a sampling of people that large and only one person out of shape, but Rathstein brushed it aside from his mind. They were probably all friends who'd met at the same gym or something.

The eerie sound of voices drifted to Rathstein's ears. It seemed like the next group was drawing close. Not wasting any more time, Rathstein headed to the closest door and knocked three times. He waited and knocked twice more, then flung it open and hurried through. He emerged in the employee break room that led out to the lobby where they first met their groups. It was a useful little system the boss had developed; the lack of back tunnels for the staff to move through had freed up plenty of room in which to stuff more attractions. Rathstein checked his makeup in the mirror then hustled out to meet his next group of charges.

He hoped this one would have more hot girls and fewer muscular males.



## 55.

When Alice first walked into the new room she noticed the style more than anything else. It looked like an abandoned morgue. Gurneys were flipped over and left on the ground, doors to the freezer drawers hung open or had been ripped from the hinges entirely, and the whole room was bathed in a dim green light that reflected off the stained emerald tiles. Whoever built these scenes went to a lot of trouble; that was evident. There were bloody handprints scraping at the walls like someone had been dragged off, and a few scraps of clothing next to a forgotten name badge.

“Creepy,” Alice whispered to herself. Only after she’d thoroughly soaked in the eerie ambiance did she face her traveling companions. That was when she got a genuine fright.

“What the hell?”

“Yeah, that was our reaction too,” Rich said. He was dressed in a long coat with a top hat and carried a teacup in his pocket for when people asked who he was supposed to be. There were still three others besides Alice, but Vince and Camille had been replaced by Rich and Mary. “Looks like the rumors of them having a few Supers on hand are true; the doors must be portals.”

“Portals that randomize where each person comes out,” Nick added. It figured he would be the one person Alice was still stuck with. She wondered if his little luck ability had any bearing on this arrangement.

“Maybe random, maybe not,” Mary said. “All we know is they shuffled the group, possibly just to add one more element of the unexpected to the mix. It does leave one with an unstable feeling, after all.”

“Random or not, let’s just get this show on the road and head toward the lounge,” Alice suggested.

“Great idea,” Rich agreed. “Any thoughts on how?”

Alice looked around the room once more, realizing for the first time what the others had already observed. In all of the gory details that made this room come alive one rudimentary piece was missing.

There was no door, only smooth emerald tiles rippling across every wall.

\* \* \*

“Maybe we have to turn the statue’s head?” Alex tossed out.

“Good an idea as any,” Hershel agreed. He and Alex had wound up in the same room, an Egyptian-style tomb with scenes of bloody sacrifices adorning the walls. There was also a statue of Anubis in one corner next to a few sarcophagi, so the duo headed over to investigate it.

“I still can’t believe they split us up like this,” Alex said appreciatively. “It was a hell of a slick move. These guys really go above and beyond.”

“True. At least we wound up with a friend. I’m not sure I’d have been as receptive to the change-up if I’d gotten someone I wasn’t on such good terms with.”

“Oh yeah, we totally lucked out. If we can’t run the maze with our girlfriends, running it with a buddy is almost as cool,” Alex agreed. He reached Anubis first, grasping the statue by the snout and tugging it right then left. Anubis held fast, his stony neck offering up not even a bit of give. “No dice.”

“Crap.” Hershel leaned against a sarcophagus propped against the wall. To his surprise he felt the lid slide a hair or so to the side. Hershel turned around and pushed the lid, moving it all of the way over and revealing an exit into a dimly lit tunnel.

“Nice job,” Alex complimented. “How’d you ever know that was there?”

Hershel shrugged. “Just lucky I guess. Let’s see what’s next.”

Alex nodded his agreement and the two boys plunged onward into mystery.

\* \* \*

Vince was not one for superstitions, generally speaking. He simply didn’t have it in him to believe that throwing salt or avoiding ladders could significantly influence how life unfurled before him. Truthfully, until meeting Nick, he likely would have said he wasn’t even an adamant believer in the concept of luck. Be all of that as it was, Vince was finding himself rapidly becoming a believer in at least one superstitious constant: Murphy’s Law.

It wasn't that the first room he'd wound up in was particularly challenging. It had merely been a series of plaster skeletons painted to look gory, as though the flesh had been rendered off of them. The trick to that room was finding the skull tucked away in a corner and placing it on the skeleton missing a head. Reuniting the two triggered a switch that opened a door in the wall and just like that, the way to the next adventure had been cleared.

It wasn't that he was scared, either. Vince had spent most of his life walking in darkness so as not to be noticed. Remote locations, unexplained noises, dim lighting, these things were no more terrifying to him than a white picket fence would be to normal people. Even in the haunted house, it had only been the surprises of people leaping out that caused his adrenaline to surge. With that stimulus gone, his perception of terror was rapidly retreating.

It wasn't even that he was upset about his group being rearranged, specifically. He grasped that it was part of the fun of such a place, expecting the unexpected and having one's preconceptions turned on their head. He understood the need for such a practice; however, this specific outcome seemed to indicate someone up in the cosmos must bear a grudge against him.

"I think I see another room ahead," Vince said, his voice bouncing off the walls. "See how the light changes to a red glow?"

"I know what a fucking change in lighting means. It's our third goddamned room. I'm not stupid, despite what you might think," Sasha snapped, her teeth practically dripping in venom.

Vince opened his mouth to apologize then thought better of it. He'd tried talking a few times, only to relay necessary information or discuss strategy, and that had pretty much been the constant reaction. So instead of focusing on communicating, he turned his attention to getting this maze the hell over with. Hopefully, if that sly old dog Murphy wasn't up to his usual tricks, there would only be a few rooms left to go.

If Vince had been more superstitious, he would have known that such thoughts are like chum to the gods of mischief.

## 56.

It was no surprise to Nick that his group was the first to arrive in the rhythmically thumping lounge with red light cascading from the ceilings. He had something of a knack for mazes and puzzles, plus Rich had proven to be more observant than expected. The result was four people cutting a veritable swath through the variety of rooms after their initial slow start in the morgue (the secret had been to open one of the corpse drawers that was actually a tunnel). Nick glanced at the party-filled room, immediately assessing the variety of costumed revelers and noting that none of the others he knew were yet present. He briefly considered putting his sunglasses back on, but with only the crimson lighting and a night spent without his eyes adjusted to less light, it was a recipe to invite disaster. Besides, Nick enjoyed his pirate outfit and the glasses took away from the effect.

“I think I see a booth.” Alice pointed to a corner of the lounge with a black and orange booth that was either currently empty or populated by people in exceptional Invisible Man costumes. It looked large enough to contain the bulk of their party, which was no small feat.

Nick nodded his agreement and the four hustled over. They made it just before another set of partiers their age, these dressed like a famous rock group, arrived. Some dirty looks were exchanged, but all of the faux musicians scampered away in short order. Dim as they were, it was clear the four already in the booth were utterly unconcerned by their ire.

“We could have invited them to join us,” Mary said as the brightly-colored marching uniforms slinked away.

“Pass,” Rich said. “I don’t associate with the lower beings unless I have to.”

“Lower beings?” Alice was surprised at the shard of anger in her voice.

“Consider your audience carefully,” Nick cautioned. “It’s been a pleasant night so far.”

“Relax, I’m not talking about you guys. Previous freaks or not, now you’re more important. I’m talking about humans.”

“I’m not sure if that’s better,” Alice replied.

Rich rolled his eyes. “Fine, my mistake. You weren’t exactly rolling out the red carpet either.”

“That’s because we wanted to save room for everyone else,” Alice said.

“Whatever, forget about it.”

“I’m not sure I want to. Do you really think of humans as lesser people?”

“It’s not an opinion, it’s fact. They’re weaker, slower, dumber, all around less-capable entities. Don’t paint me as an asshole for saying what all of us think.”

“Everyone doesn’t think that,” Mary said, her voice barely audible over the same background music that protected their conversation.

“I guess you’d know. Look, I’m done with this line of discussion. Let’s drop it, shall we?”

“I’m fine with that,” Nick agreed. He’d known enough people like Rich to see that there was no traction to be made in arguing. “How about a different topic? Tell us about the talent that makes you better than human, Rich.”

“Nice try, but I’m not doling out hints about how to beat me, either.”

“I didn’t mean like that. You don’t have to give away weaknesses; I’m just curious what exactly happens to people when you freeze them up. Are they stuck watching you or something?” Nick inquired.

“Not really. The truth is I seal them away inside their own minds. I can construct a delusion for them to wander around in, or just plunk them into their own subconscious and leave them to meander.” Rich said. A blaring note of pride was quite conspicuous in his voice.

“That sounds pretty cool,” Alice complimented.

“It comes in handy.”

“I like it, but I’m not sure how effective it would be,” Nick said. “I mean, someone with mental training could probably free themselves once they knew it was all fake.”

“Trust me,” Rich assured him, “They don’t.”

“Whatever you say, Chief. I’m getting a drink.” Nick began to scoot along the vinyl, bumping Mary to force her to move with him so he could get free.

“You think it’s that easy to overcome?”

“Not at all,” Mary said, trying to calm him.

“I’m just pointing out that the only person we’ve seen it work on is Roy, and he’s not really an intellectual juggernaut,” Nick prodded.

“Let’s test your theory, then.” Rich drove his knee upward, slamming it into the bottom of the table. The noise wasn’t loud enough to draw looks from beyond their area, but it did startle everyone at the booth into glancing in his direction. That glance was all it took; in the moment they met his eyes, Rich sealed all three of them away. Their bodies froze in place, the muscles tensing enough to hold their positions. Nick and Mary were awkwardly propped against each other, the unfortunate outcome of being in movement when stopped. Alice, at least, looked a bit more natural. Rich could have let them go limp, or stowed them into some maniacal hell-dream that would have them freaking out; however, he sensed that would have led to more trouble than it was worth. Instead he’d just chunked them into their own subconscious without bothering to give their illusion any shape. They’d still be pissed, but it would show that loud-mouth Nick just whose power was weak.

Rich looked around to see if there was a waitress anywhere near. He couldn’t very well leave them like this, yet he greatly wanted a drink. Using his power always gave him cotton-mouth, though for the life of him he could never figure out why. The unrelenting music bouncing off the walls wasn’t exactly making him more comfortable, either. Ah well, at least he didn’t have to deal with incessant yapping coupled with an overblown bass line.

\* \* \*

“I haven’t found anything yet.” Vince very much wanted to ask her if she had more success, however he knew if he did she’d snap back that if she had wouldn’t she have told him. In truth he doubted she would, it was more likely Sasha would just open the passageway and continue on without so much as a grunt of indication.

“Keep looking.” You could have chilled a lake with the ice in her voice. The two of them had hit a frustrating snag with this latest room. It was built to look like an outdoor graveyard, complete with bursts of chilling winds, lush green grass, and grey marble headstones bursting forth from soft,

malleable dirt. The designer had even engraved each of the headstones; Vince walked past one where the name had been worn away but “1818 – 1857. Died by drowning” was still visible. The edges of the room were dark and obscured; one had to walk right up to them and grope around to feel anything solid. It was truly a masterpiece of craftsmanship, one that Vince would have probably enjoyed far more in different circumstances. Unfortunately, the room was more difficult to find a way out of than any of the previous ones, and his company was growing more and more irritable with each passing minute.

“This is bullshit, there has to be a way out!” Sasha’s wrath had tweaked her voice to a higher level than normal.

“I’m sure we’ll find it eventually,” Vince assured her. “These things aren’t meant to actually keep people in, after all.”

“Oh, fuck you, I bet you’re loving this.”

“Yes, Sasha, this is my greatest dream realized at last.”

“Just look harder, dickhead.”

Vince bit his tongue and redoubled his efforts. Baseless accusations aside, he would have rather been in a Coach George workout session than in this room with Sasha. He just hoped his patience would hold until he managed to escape to sweet, sweet freedom.

## 57.

Mary was in the woods. These weren't just any random cluster of trees though, these were her woods. She tread along the small path, one that had been carved by her own feet through the years, and breathed deep of the clean air and silence. She'd forgotten how quiet her woods were, how peaceful they made her feel. This wasn't just a telepathic silence, either; that one she could now achieve on her own. This was a world without car horns and buzzing electric lines and humming air conditioners. This was a place of peace. Well... almost. Every now and then Mary caught a sound from another direction, something like the sound her parents' change had made when she'd knocked it from the counter as a child. Mary didn't know why that memory crystallized so clearly; she'd barely been three at the time. For a moment she could swear she saw that toddler version of herself peeking back from behind a tall oak, but then she blinked and it was gone.

The rogue sound persisted. It came in snippets, always out of sight, but always from the same direction. It was off to the east. Mary didn't know what it could be; in that direction was a small lake that she'd splashed about in when the sun grew oppressively hot. It wasn't lake weather today: it was a perfect temperature, the kind where she could have lounged among the leaves until sunset. The noise didn't want to let her; however, it insisted upon intruding in her woods, poaching her precious peace with its chittering tones.

It came again and Mary adjusted her direction. She would attend to whatever it was and then resume her day. She hadn't been home for a long time, and even if she couldn't remember how she'd come to be here, Mary was going to damned well enjoy herself. As she walked, it seemed like the light slipping through the trees was changing. It had been a slightly overcast but bright day when she was on her path, now the sun was glowing a hot yellow overhead. The canopy began to thicken, the leaves turning from their emerald green to a steadily deepening autumn red. A curiosity splashed against the bulwark of Mary's peace. Why were the leaves changing? It wasn't the right season for that, was it? Mary began to realize she didn't know what season it was, or what day it was. With every step she was becoming increasingly aware of how little sense this all made. How had she even gotten back here? Hadn't she been somewhere... doing something... with some people? The memories were resisting her, but Mary was becoming more dogged in her insistence that they appear.



She glanced around and realized the canopy had turned into a red ceiling, dozens of mini-suns glaring down at her from its crimson heights. No, not suns. Light bulbs; it was a ceiling with seemingly endless recessed lights. The trees were no longer very tree-shaped either. They'd thinned out and taken on a silver shimmer. Each had only a single branch, angled upward at its side like an arm raised to answer a question. The fronts seemed to have strange symbols on them; Mary stared closely at one before realizing it looked like a crude drawing of a lemon. A tickle in the back of her mind insisted she knew this peculiar shape, but she just couldn't access it. Instead she plodded onward, making note of what changed as she did. The trees were shrinking; the tallest ones now stood only around seven feet tall. They were getting boxier, too. As she moved forward, Mary noticed mushrooms in front of the trees were growing tall, with wider red tops and black stems. She brushed the tops of one and found it soft, yet the stem was cold and hard.

"Stools," Mary said softly. She didn't understand why it wouldn't come earlier; that was obviously what the mushrooms were changing in to. Maybe it was because in her forest there were no stools, so such knowledge in this place served no purpose. This wasn't her forest anymore; it hadn't been for nearly half a mile. Mary rolled that thought around in her brain. She knew how far she'd walked, but her feet weren't sore at all, and despite her brisk pace she'd never once taken a ragged breath. This wasn't right at all.

Mary began to run forward, the silver box trees whipping by her in an increasingly swift blur. She never could have moved this quickly before, why was it so effortless now? The world slipped past her, the trees and mushrooms seeming to move like a flip book, each passing one becoming identical with the others around it. All at once Mary burst forth from the trees and found herself standing in a room that positively dripped with the tinkling sound she'd heard in the woods. Now it was no longer a gentle annoyance, it was an overbearing anthem encasing her. It was the sound of coins cascading onto metal, and an electronic mimic was being blared by every slot machine in the room, of which there were hundreds.

"Slot machines." That's what the trees had been turning into, why couldn't she see that before? Mary stood on the threshold of the lobby, a row of slots to her back and a beautiful marble floor only one step away. Upon it were tables lined with green felt, bars set up strategically at key intervals, and nothing even close to resembling a window to the outside. There were people, too: big men in striped suits, older couples rhythmically tugging the arms of machines that refused to pay out, tall women in skimpy clothes carting drinks

to the cheerful gamblers. Mary had heard about places like this, she'd seen them featured in movies, but never in her life had she actually been to a casino. Given the high emotion and packed population, it would have been an indescribable hell in her Powered days. She wondered how such a place had manifested in her woods, and without thinking, she took that final step onto the main floor.

Mary nearly doubled over at the bursting sensation that ripped through her head as soon as her foot made contact with the polished marble. It all came flooding back, everything that existed outside her forest. Lander, Alice, George, the match, Halloween, the look in Rich's eye as he'd stared at them... and then it all made sense.

Mary picked herself up slowly, making sure there weren't going to be any aftershocks from that mental dam breaking. Everything seemed to be responding appropriately so she started to venture forward. She'd nearly forgotten Rich could induce paralyzing illusions in people's minds. It seemed she had something of a travel visa; at least this certainly didn't seem like her mind anymore. That would explain why she was aware of her predicament, perhaps. As her sneakers trod across the ground, she made sure to take in as many details as possible. Unless Alice had a gambling problem she'd hidden exceptionally well for the past year, Mary had a strong hunch of just whose brain she was taking a tour of and this was not an opportunity to be squandered.

## 58.

“Where is the fucking exit from this place?” Sasha yelled, her voice echoing outward across the marble headstones. She kicked a patch of grass and sent dirt flying into the air. They’d been stuck in the same room for nearly ten minutes and her original demeanor was positively divine compared to the funk she’d degenerated into.

“I’m sure we’ll find it,” Vince assured her. He examined another headstone, reading the inscription, checking to see if it had any give and feeling around for hidden compartments.

“Like you’re even trying.”

“I promise you, I am doing my best to get us free from this place.”

“Oh, wow, you promise? Now if only you weren’t a lying fuckwad who’d spent a year deceiving me that would mean something. Too bad.”

Vince held his tongue yet again and moved on to another grave. Sasha was right: he had lied to her. He’d lied to everyone, and regardless of what his reasons were, he had to accept the consequences. He just wished the consequences would let it be for a few minutes.

Sasha was in no mood to let up, unfortunately. This was her first real time alone with Vince since the revelation, and at long last her stewing anger had an appropriate outlet. “I bet you already found the exit when we got here, you’ve just been keeping it secret.”

“You’ve looked almost everywhere I’ve looked,” Vince pointed out.

“Right, because you’d never do something like conceal the truth so others couldn’t find it.”

“Sasha, I don’t disagree that I lied to you about what I was before we met. That doesn’t mean everything I’ve told you is a lie, and it doesn’t mean that I want to stay in this fake graveyard while you yell at me all night.”

“And why should I believe that? You spent a year lying to keep me near, what makes this any different?”

“Because whoever you are tonight isn’t the girl I fell in love with. You’re angry, you’re loud, and you seem to lack empathy for anything outside of yourself. Now, I’ll take responsibility for what I did and I’ll not stop

apologizing if you want to hear it, but that doesn't mean I want to be around you like this. Trust me: no one wants to get away from here more than me." Vince stared at her, watching Sasha's throat bob up and down as her face flexed through a variety of emotions too quick and too complex for Vince to make out.

"Fuck this, I'm getting out of here," Sasha said at last. She'd regained most of her composure, but some of the fire seemed to have gone out of her voice.

"How?"

"How else, jackass? I'm going to tear this whole place apart until I find the door. Shouldn't take more than a minute."

Vince jumped up from his position of perching over a headstone. "You can't! Remember the signs at the front? They said every room had cameras for surveillance."

"Who cares?" Sasha knew she was being obstinate just for the sake of it, but she couldn't help herself.

"If anyone who watches that video goes to Lander or is even associated with the college you could be reported. You'd be gone before Christmas."

Sasha looked at him; all he wore on his face was concern. Vince had come as close to calling her a bitch as someone like him was capable of, yet he still cared that she was putting herself in danger. For some reason, that made her already knotted stomach twist in a horrifying new direction.

"Worth the risk." Sasha took a step back and prepared to start her rampage through the graves. Vince's strong hand closed around her arm, not squeezing but still holding her firm.

"What about Jill's secret? Or Camille's? Rich, Chad, Alex, all of them are your friends and you're putting them at risk. We came here together, we all moved as a group. It doesn't take a genius to figure out if you're a Super we might be, too."

Sasha pulled a little and found Vince's grip unyielding.

"I don't want you to do something stupid and endanger yourself, but given our past, I don't think I have the right to stop you. However, this isn't just about you. What you do right now can seriously impact the people who

trust you. So even if this sucks for a while, just try and bear with it. Please.”

*You’re so centered on Vince lying to you and the betrayal you feel over that, have you ever stopped to really ask yourself why he did it?*

“You’re such a bastard.” Sasha didn’t turn around; she kept her eyes trained on the dark edges of the room. Everything seemed a little blurrier than before, and Sasha felt something warm on her cheek. “You can’t even let me hate you properly.”

“I’m sorry.” Vince let go of her arm but didn’t make any other motions. She was clearly facing away from him on purpose; he didn’t want to move until she was ready to be seen.

“Of course you’re sorry. You’re always sorry for things you even think you did wrong. I want you to tell me something: why did you lie?”

“Excuses don’t matter, I still did it.”

“I’m the one who got deceived. I get to decide what matters and what doesn’t.” Sasha pretended to run a hand through the side of her hair so she could wipe away the tears with her wrist. It wasn’t a very fluid motion, and she doubted it fooled him, but it was the best she could do.

“I guess that’s fair. We weren’t supposed to tell anyone for our own safety. We didn’t know how people would react. We had a hunch it would put us in danger, at the very least.”

“I’m not asking why you lied to everyone. I’m asking why you lied to me. After everything we shared, after all that time together, did you really think you couldn’t risk your secret with me?”

Vince hesitated, contemplating what to say next. He’d asked himself that question so many times over the past few months, and imagined just as many variations of what he would tell Sasha if given the opportunity currently before him. In the end, he went with the only thing that had ever seemed acceptable to answer with: the truth. “I would have taken the chance and trusted you; I really believe I would have. But it wasn’t my risk to take.”

“You were worried about the others.”

“I was. Letting this out changed everything. It’s made us pariahs and targets. For the rest of our lives we’ll be known as the first batch of freaks, the ones who changed everything. We’ll never get normal lives, not even what passes for normal in the world of Supers. I couldn’t gamble everyone’s future

on my faith in anyone, not even the girl I loved. It wouldn't have been right. Not that what I did was right, either. I had a hard choice and I made it. I'm sorry it hurt you."

"Me, too," Sasha said. "Look, let's just work together and get out of here, okay?"

"Okay," Vince agreed.

"I'll check the tombstones on the left, you do the ones on the right. Sooner or later we'll crack this thing," Sasha instructed. She headed off toward some graves, doing her best to wipe away the remaining tears as covertly as possible. Vince noticed, of course, but he didn't say anything; instead he went back to work.

Though they were still trapped in a spooky graveyard room in the middle of a maze, it was curiously peaceful now that all the yelling had dispersed.

## 59.

The world of Nick's mind was ridiculously detailed. Mary could hardly believe the intricate design of the tile floor, or the way the occasional table would bear scratches and scuffs, or how every person she encountered was wholly unique. It was evident they weren't real people, of course; no matter how well-crafted the cigar-puffing men or scantily-clad waitresses were, they still grew hazy at the edges, identifying them as mere chunks of Nick's mind rather than flesh and blood. Because of that blurring effect, Mary was instantly able to recognize Nick when she found him, which was fortunate because she likely would have missed him otherwise.

Despite the glimpses she'd had into his thoughts, Mary had always imagined the Nick she knew was just a slight variation on the real one. Surely he didn't wear those silly sunglasses or act as purposefully confounding when he was away from Lander, but she assumed many of his other habits and fashions remained the same. As her eyes fell across the well-dressed young man raking in chips at the poker table, Mary realized just how wrong that assumption had been. His hair was styled in an expert manner, the suit that whispered across his form had clearly been crafted specifically for him, but most distinctive of all was his face. The Nick she knew generally wore a look of affable ignorance, as if he was merely wandering through the world and chuckling at the things that fell across his path. This Nick didn't conceal his intellect; his eyes roved the world in front of him and devoured every detail they could find. There were no emotions, not even fake ones, decorating his visage. He gave away nothing and took in everything: that was the essence of Nicholas Campbell.

Mary approached slowly, taking the seat of a man who stalked away with a sad look and presumably lighter pockets. The dealer looked at her with a curious glance, and Mary suddenly realized she didn't have any money to enter the game. The dealer motioned for her to leave and she began to slide off the chair's vinyl red cushion.

"She stays." Nick's voice wasn't a command, nor was it a request. He spoke like he was calmly discussing geography or math, things that were simply fact. There was no room for denial in his tone; what he said simply was.

"Thank you," Mary replied, readjusting in her seat.

“No problem.” Nick motioned in the air and a waitress materialized at his side. She carried a clear glass with a brown liquid inside, which she placed next to Nick while collecting the empty ones he’d presumably already drained. Mary noticed the girl had long blonde hair and a familiar facial structure, but declined from mentioning it.

“So your power lets you come into my brain now, huh?”

Mary tilted her head in surprise. “You already know where we are?”

“I didn’t originally. The owl was a good hint.” Nick pointed to the ceiling where Mary could see a snowy white bird sailing between the chandeliers. She recognized it immediately; that species had frequented her forest since before she’d moved to it.

“How did that get here?”

“My guess is that you accidentally pulled some of your world into mine when you made the trip. I didn’t start noticing the inconsistencies around here until a few minutes ago, so maybe you crossing over broke whatever part of Rich’s ability keeps us unaware that we’re in an illusion.”

“Seems closer to a dream.”

“Or a carefully controlled coma if we’re splitting hairs. Anyway, the point is, I could sense something that didn’t belong, and that’s when I started getting a feeling none of this was right.”

“You have to admit, this is kind of neat.”

“Of course you’d think that,” Nick scowled. “You’re not the one with a stranger traipsing around in your head.”

“Nothing we can do about it until he frees us.”

“I wouldn’t say that.” Nick turned his attention back to the cards just as a pair of hulking male figures appeared behind Mary’s chair. “See, this is place is a perfect replica of my casino, which means the things around here were pulled from my brain rather than constructed by Rich. Knowing that, I can’t just let you wander about. My friends here will show you to the mandatory hospitality suite until we’re both back in the real world.”

“Come on, Nick, aren’t you being silly?”

“I’ve made it comfortable and lavish, so try to take it as a courtesy. I can’t stop you from digging through my thoughts but I’ll be damned if I’ll



have you peering through keyholes into the deeper parts of my mind.”

A rough hand settled on Mary’s shoulder. It wasn’t forceful, but it was there to send a clear message.

“If you’d asked nicely I would have promised to just sit here with you. I’m a little insulted by the goon squad; I think it’s time for them to leave.” Mary sent a blast of telekinetic energy toward each thug, enough to drive them into and through the walls. Since they weren’t real she didn’t bother with holding back, which made it all the more surprising when neither of them moved an inch.

“Oh, Mary, did you really think your powers would work in here? This is my mind, after all.”

Mary tried again, and again, and again as the security agent on the right gently pulled her from the table and began to escort her toward a set of stairs leading downward.

“Why not just let me stay with you?” Mary called over her shoulder.

“Nothing personal, but I don’t trust you. Besides, I have things to do,” Nick replied, rising from the table and turning his back on the stack of chips resting on the green felt. “A man rarely gets lucid access to a world his own brain has created. This is an opportunity I don’t intend to squander.”

Mary struggled slightly against her muscular escorts, but found neither of them loosened their grips in the slightest. She wasn’t surprised. Nick had already made the truth evident: this was his world, she was merely visiting it. The most she could do was speculate whether he’d been serious about the luxury of her cell and hope Rich released them in short order. Plus think of all the ways she was going to painfully pay him back for this when they got free.

## 60.

“Ig and Ook?” The two suited figures continued down the hall, each one resting a hand on Mary’s closest shoulder. The hallway was sparse, nothing but stone on every surface, only interrupted by the occasional door. With each one Mary would tense in anticipation, expecting them to hurl her inside and complete her incarceration. So far they had merely kept walking, the final door of her journey not yet having appeared before them.

“Tweedle Dee and Tweedle Dum?” No reaction. Mary was amusing herself by trying to guess the names of her guards. She realized it was possible they were new creations cobbled together just for this purpose, beings who had no real names, but then again it wasn’t like she had anything else to do. She’d already tried reading their minds and moving things with her telekinesis. So far Nick’s words had held true; as long as she was in his mind, her powers didn’t exist. Except they did, in that they were what allowed her to be here in the first place. It was a bit confusing and had begun to give Mary a headache, hence why so moved onto the simpler game of name guessing.

“Watson and Holmes? Kit and Kat? Cloak and Dagger? Come on, guys, and least tell me if I’m hot or cold.” Her attendants remained silent, but as Mary glanced up at them, she noticed a large hand wrap around each of their skulls. With one swift movement and a sharp cracking sound, the two craniums had been struck together and the escorts were collapsed in a heap. Mary turned slowly around, trying to figure out just who there was to help her in a place like this. Whatever she’d expected, what she found was quite different.

“I believe they’re called Tick and Tock,” said Mary’s rescuer. He was tall and lean, with a bald head, a sharp nose, and otherwise unremarkable features except for his eyes. His eyes seemed to sparkle with kindness; they made him seem like the kind of person to be instantly and completely trusted. Given whose mind Mary was currently trespassing in, it was a quality that had the effect of leaving her exceptionally suspicious. “Their names change with Nick’s moods. Mine is more stable; you may call me Gerry.”

“Thanks for the help, Gerry,” Mary said skeptically. “But I’m a little confused. Nick wants me sealed up, and everything in here is a part of Nick’s brain, so why did you knock out the guards?”

Gerry gave her a reassuring smile. “A person is made of more than

singular desires. Often they have conflicting impulses, powerful inclinations for things that are opposite in nature. Tick and Tock are part of Nick's extensive defensive army, the part of him that keeps distance between his heart and the rest of the world."

"So what are you?"

"I'm the part of Nick that wants to connect to other people. The real Gerry is the one who is largely responsible for my existence, hence why I look this way. He's quite likely the only person in the world Nick truly trusts, let alone loves. His influence left a crack in your friend's otherwise impenetrable outer shell."

"I see. Is that why you saved me?" Mary still wasn't sure she believed this new mental figment; however, she had to admit he was more pleasant than the last ones.

"Partially. It's mostly because Nick is trying to find a place in here he shouldn't go. I need you to stop him."

"Why can't you do it?"

"I'm a piece of him; my input was registered in the subconscious already. It was ignored, as usual, unfortunately. So I've decided to pursue more drastic measures."

"Like using a trespasser to interfere for you. Nice catch of a loophole. You really are a part of Nick."

"Guilty as charged."

"I have to ask: what reason do I have to trust you? I'm not certain going deeper into Nick's mind is the safest recreational activity."

"Mary, right now we are already under the surface layer of his subconscious, that's why I was able to come help you. Down here I'm an independent component. If you want to wander around without me that's your choice, but keep in mind that there are far more components to Nick than just myself and the twins. Very few of them are as pleasant as we, and some of them can be downright horrifying. They do have one thing in common you should be aware of: in this place they're all quite real."

"You make a compelling case. Lead the way," Mary said quickly. For the first time she was beginning to understand just how vulnerable she was without her powers. Gerry might be lying out of his ass; however, he at least

seemed to have a purpose for saving her. It was the kind of self-serving logic she could believe when dealing with Nick, so she was willing to acknowledge it would make sense for a chunk of his mind to work along the same lines.

At this point, all she could do was follow along and hope Rich woke them up soon.

## 61.

The shape of Alice's subconscious might have surprised people who were unfamiliar with her. It wasn't the large, lavish estate she'd grown up on. That had felt more like a prison in her formative years, a place she was sealed away lest she get too happy and go floating off. It also wasn't anything from her later life; despite her love of Lander and the people she'd met there, everything about it tended to bubble with stress and worry. Those elements made it unsuitable for a mental stronghold; such places are meant to be points of comfort and serenity. No, Alice's subconscious was formed in the shape of the only location where she'd ever really been able to let the world and the worries all melt away.

Alice sipped champagne as the expert beautician worked feverously on her pedicure. She'd already sampled the spa's mud bath and steam room, after this she planned on a lengthy massage to get that pesky knot in her shoulder out. Once that was done, well, who could say where her whimsy would take her? This facility was massive, gleaming white and thick with the scent of candles. It teemed with capable staff ready to accommodate her every desire. Certainly there were a few locked doors that led to deeper areas where things wouldn't be quite so pleasant, but Mary had burst into Nick's mind and restored awareness, not Alice's. So Alice was just fine letting those doors stay locked; she had neither the inclination nor the capacity to go mind-spelunking.

"My, this is a strange scenario." The voice came from behind Alice's chair. It was foreign, yet refined and cultured. Alice prided herself on her ability to discern one's upbringing from their speech patterns, and this one had been strongly influenced by the necessities of high society.

"I didn't realize there were any other customers here today. Please, take a seat and join me." Alice had no particular inclinations to share her space; however, someone with a voice like that probably had the sort of power and influence her father fastidiously cultivated. He'd be more than a little put-out if she inadvertently snubbed someone of influence.

"I appreciate the invitation." The voice stepped forward to reveal the man it was connected to. He was tall, though not exceptionally so. His cocoa skin was clad in a well-constructed suit that eschewed the tie in favor of an open-throat shirt. He smiled at Alice with unexpected warmth and she had the

strangest sense of déjà vu.

“My pleasure. Would you care for some champagne, Mr...”

“Abridail. Just call me Abridail.”

“Very well, would you care for some champagne, Abridail?”

“Gladly. Not often I see places like this. I feel like I should enjoy it.” Within moments a fresh sparkling glass arrived at his side. He sipped it thoughtfully, pausing to appreciate the quality of the bubbling wine.

“So, if I may inquire, your name is rather unique. Is there a story behind it, or perhaps a unique cultural origin?”

“No, it’s just a fake name I use when I’m off Walking,” Abridail replied, taking another sip. “On the rare occasion people remember me I don’t want them able to track me down.”

“Forgive me, what do you mean by ‘off Walking’?”

“Walking through dreams. Don’t feel bad if you didn’t know this was one; most people don’t. It’s a strange one at that, even for dreams. Barely even qualifies as one. It’s more like someone stuck a blank canvas on display and called it art.”

“This doesn’t seem to make much sense,” Alice said, her relaxation bubble beginning to quiver as it neared a full on burst.

“Don’t worry, it will soon. Once you accept it’s a dream, you get a higher level of control. You tend to like that.”

“Tend to? How would you know that?”

“I’ve visited you in many dreams, Alice. Unfortunately, you’re such a deep sleeper you never remember them. I only keep plugging away because I’m a man of my word and I have a message to deliver.”

“What kind of message can only be delivered through dreams?”

“The sort that is so delicate no one is crazy enough to whisper it aloud, lest God himself should overhear.”

Alice hesitated, and the world around them seemed to flicker. “I’m not sure I’d want to hear a message like that. It sounds like a burden.”

“I won’t lie to you, that’s exactly what it is. But once you build up

your courage with a few starter questions you'll ask about it. You always do."

"If you say so. This message of yours, who is it from, anyway?"

Abridail gave her another warm smile and finished off his champagne. "That's the part that generally piques your interest in the first place. The truth of it is, I'm here on behalf of your mother."

\* \* \*

"So what is Nick trying to do that's so dangerous anyway?" Mary's words came easy despite the brisk pace at which she and Gerry were cutting through the hall. They'd taken a multitude of twists and turns and descended several more staircases in a very brief time. The scenery was changing as they progressed. While it was still only halls and doors, they'd ceased looking quite so inviting. Instead of red wood most of the doors now were made from steel with large locks securing their knobs in place. It was evident they were going into the more defended parts of Nick's mind, which Mary might have felt some reluctance in viewing if she wasn't being escorted by a part of Nick. It still felt a bit ethically sticky, however, she reassured herself she hadn't seen anything but doors so it's not like she was snooping.

"He's looking for a memory that doesn't exist," Gerry informed her. "He's working off the belief that while in his mind he can view parts of his past that he can't recall while conscious."

Mary remembered how easily she'd recalled the sound of knocking the change from the counter when she was three. "He might be right."

"Of course he's right. Still, there's a threshold; a person would have had to be old enough to interpret all the various things around them and put them in context to form a valid memory. What he's searching for goes beyond that point."

"If it doesn't exist, then why are you so worried?"

"Because while a real record doesn't exist, he's fantasized about it so many times that there's a lot of realistic looking fakes down here."

"Can't he tell the difference?"

"If it were something he was more objective about, then probably. In this case, I have serious doubts."

"Gerry, exactly what memory is Nick looking for?" Mary felt a cold

tickle up her spine. There was a lot about Nick that spoke to more than was on the surface and hinted at a past with some misfortune and complexities. She wasn't entirely sure she wanted to get too close to something that made even the ever-detached Nick too emotional to use reason.

Gerry shook his head. "I can't tell you that. I think you need to know it, but telling you would overstep the bounds of what I can do."

"Won't I see it when we catch up to Nick anyway?"

"We're not trying to catch Nick. There are too many places he could be."

"Then where are we going?"

"We're going to most protected place in his entire psyche. If he senses anything foreign there, he'll drop what he's doing and come to intercept you," Gerry explained.

"Won't that make him mad?"

"Absolutely. But it won't destroy him."

"I'll take it to mean this other thing could," Mary surmised.

"Smart girl."

"Must be one hell of a day he wants to remember."

Gerry nodded. "You'll understand more when we arrive."

"I thought we were going somewhere different than the place Nick is searching for."

"We are, but the two are connected. That's really all I can say. Sorry, but I'm only a piece of the whole; there are limits I can't overcome."

"I won't say I understand, because this is all pretty insane, but I take your meaning."

"That will do for now," Gerry assured her. "Keep your eyes peeled. We're almost there."



## 62.

Chad, Will, Jill, and Camille all stepped into the lounge from the maze and were overcome by the shift in scenery. Going from the forced creepy quiet of the various scenes into the red lighting and thumping bass of the new environment was like slipping from a sunny beach into a nearly frozen icy pool. They adjusted in short order, and set about searching for their comrades.

The group had made good time through the labyrinth after their initial confusion at Camille's appearance in place of Rich, though they'd found themselves stumped enough times to place their exit sometime after Rich had sent the others into their own minds. Chad spotted his teammate almost immediately, walking over to the table and motioning to the others to join him. As Chad grew nearer he noticed the stiff way in which Nick, Mary, and Alice sat. They blinked and breathed but did little else. To someone who hadn't worked with Rich before they might have been mistaken for bored listeners. Chad knew better; he'd seen that posture in too many conquered opponents to mistake it for anything else.

"You sealed them."

"Not even a hello? I'm a little hurt," Rich replied.

"Why would you do that?"

"Nick was questioning the validity of my power, so it seemed a live demonstration was in order."

"In the middle of a crowded room, with countless witnesses, any of whom might have seen what happened and put it all together." Chad's tone left no uncertainty that he was unhappy, and much as Rich liked to rib his captain, he realized he needed to get a handle on this situation soon. Chad was a nice guy, but he didn't tolerate any activities that might put their secret, and therefore their standing in the HCP, at risk.

"I've kept them looking natural, don't worry," Rich assured him. "I can let them out if you want."

"Go slow and do it gently," Chad instructed him. "The last thing we need is one of them freaking out and drawing more attention to us."

"Understood," Rich said obediently. He meant it too. Chad was the one person against whom Rich had no ace in the hole. Everyone else it was

just a matter of catching their eye, but for some reason when it came to the blonde captain, Rich's mind mojo was utterly ineffective. He began the effort of pulling the frozen folks out from their delusions. He could have done it in a series of seconds, but if Chad wanted gentle it would take a bit of time. Oh well, it wasn't like it made any difference to the people he'd sealed. They were still in their own heads, blissfully killing time doing nothing important.

\* \* \*

This wasn't just a door, this was a battered vault. The entry was blocked by a circular steel front several inches thick. The walls around it had been blasted and chiseled away, leaving it slightly ajar. A multitude of chains were strewn across it, each one severed and now hanging limply. The rubble from countless guards littered the ground around Mary and Gerry's feet, some of their stone faces still twisted in the agony of their destruction. Cameras, lasers, bombs, and other defenses of the sort filled the area, all rendered useless if not outright obliterated.

"I don't understand," Mary said. "Did you do this?"

"No, Nick did."

"Then who set the defenses to begin with?"

"That was Nick, too," Gerry told her.

"That doesn't make any sense."

"Doesn't it? Haven't you ever had a thought or an idea you tried to bury away, yet in moments of weakness would come floundering up because some piece of you was unwilling to let it go?"

Mary didn't say anything to that. She couldn't imagine what an appropriate response would be.

"I told you before, humans are multifaceted. Even Nick. Part of him wants to destroy this room and purge it from his head. There's another part that refuses to let it stay forgotten."

"Which part are you?"

Gerry turned and smiled at her. "If it were up to me, I'd set an explosive charge in this bastard and never look back."

Mary nodded. If Gerry was the part of Nick that wanted to connect to the world and he abhorred this place so vehemently then it likely meant what

lay within was part of what made Nick so, well, Nickish.

“How long until he gets here?”

“Once you step inside I imagine it won’t be more than a few minutes.”

Mary cocked an eyebrow. “You want me to go in?”

“It’s the only way to draw him here.”

“Something this guarded, it sort of seems like I don’t have the right to see it.”

“Mary, this is something Nick has never even talked about with the real Gerry. It’s a secret he holds closer than any other, even though clutching it so tightly is burning him away from the inside. If he never shares the burden with someone else, I’m afraid eventually he’ll be nothing but a charred and empty husk.”

“I thought you wanted to destroy this room.”

“I do. Letting it out is the next best option.”

Mary opened her mouth then closed it. She was, ultimately, arguing with a piece of Nick about what was best for Nick. At the end of the day, she had to defer to his expertise over her own. Besides, it would be a lie to say her curiosity wasn’t piqued. Instead of objecting, she took a tentative step forward and placed her hand on the door. It was cold, like someone had dipped the steel in liquid nitrogen before fastening it in place. Mary looked back at Gerry, who nodded his encouragement. She pulled the door farther open, noticing she could only make out shadows inside. With a tentative gulp she stepped across the threshold.

The first thing she observed was that she couldn’t see outside anymore. It was just a half-circle of bright light to her back, so intense that nothing was discernible. The second thing she noticed was that her eyes had instantly adjusted and she could make out the room now, or at least parts of it. There were still spots of inky blackness dotting the small landscape, but the rest had become clear. Mary was shocked by what she saw. Of all the things she might have imagined lurked in the lair of Nick’s inner secret, this one would never have occurred to her.

Mary was standing in a church. The carpet was a dark maroon, the pews a faded wooden color, and a large cross hung over the pulpit. There were no stained glass windows, or any windows for that matter. The entire

structure seemed to be lit by candles along the walls, as well as a large cluster of them at the front. There was something else up there, too, but it was in one of the dark spots Mary's eyes couldn't penetrate. Overall the place was peaceful, quiet save for the soft sizzle of burning wicks.

Mary cocked her head. That wasn't entirely true. There was another noise in the room, so soft she'd nearly missed it. Mary began walking forward and the noise grew louder. In a pew only a few rows away from the front she found a sandy-haired boy huddled in a ball on the ground. His face was tucked into his knees, muffling his sobs as he rocked slowly back and forth. He didn't have the sunglasses or the attitude, but Mary made an intuitive leap.

"Nick?"

The boy looked up in surprise. His face was splotched and his nose was runny. It was evident he'd been crying for a very, very long time.

"Go away." His voice was weak and cracked, but there a surprising fierceness to it.

"Nick, it's okay. I'm your friend."

"I know. Now go away. I don't want to hurt you, too." His voice cracked on the word "you" and a fresh dousing of tears sprang forth.

Mary crouched down and reached out to comfort him, but the boy slapped her hand back.

"What do you mean 'you, too'?"

Nick reburied his face in his knees, but he pointed over his head toward the pulpit. Mary stood up slowly. For the first time she noticed that this Nick was wearing a small black suit. She turned forward. Even being only a few feet away, she still couldn't see what was set in the center. She took careful, awkward steps as she advanced. A church. Candles. A young boy in a black suit. Mary wondered why it had taken her so long to understand.

She was at a funeral.

When she was inches away the darkness dissipated. Sitting before her were a pair of closed brown coffins. There were pictures mounted on each one; the right casket evidently contained a once pretty girl with chestnut hair and the left bore a tall gangly man with a thick set of spectacles. She barely noticed any of that, however; it was only in memory she would discover those

details. What dominated her attention was what lay behind the coffins. It was a twisted, mangled pile of steaming black metal that might have once been a car. It looked as though it had been tossed through an industrial shredder, decimated by an angry god. There was something familiar about it, but Mary couldn't figure out what.

"What on earth happened?" Mary wasn't able to imagine the sort of accident that could have caused this level of damage.

The whimpering behind her redoubled, but Mary heard a word being choked out. She walked back to the weeping boy and crouched down once more. "I'm sorry, Nick, I couldn't hear you. What did you say?"

"...Me."

Mary felt an icicle shoot from her heart directly into her spine. "I'm sorry?"

"Me... I happened." Nick's voice was cutting through the rasping sobs that even his knees could no longer muffle. "I killed them. I killed my mom and dad."

Mary opened her mouth to respond, but before the words could get out a pair of strong hands from behind wrapped themselves around her neck and began to squeeze.

## 63.

Nick's right eye twitched and Mary's throat bobbed. It was the first signs of stirring either had shown in the last few minutes.

"About time," Rich sighed. Even bringing them out gently, this was taking longer than he expected. He'd just dropped them in the upper layers of their heads; they should have come back within a few moments. Unless, of course, they'd somehow found their way in deeper. Rich dismissed the idea. They'd need awareness to plumb their mental depths and he hadn't given it to them. No, they must just be particularly stubborn.

"You're sure they're okay?" Vince asked. He and Sasha had been the last to join the table, getting quickly up to speed on why his friends were in a catatonic state. While neither he nor anyone else from Team One was particularly pleased with the events, it didn't surprise any of them that Nick had riled Rich to the point of demonstrating his abilities. So long as the three came out without damage it seemed a harmless, if inconvenient, occurrence.

"I assure you, they're fine. The place I sent them is like the home base of their subconscious. It's built to be safe and comforting. If anything they're resisting because they're enjoying it too much," Rich explained. "I could jerk them out, but it might be a bit jarring."

"I can vouch for that," Hershel added. "Last year when Roy snapped free of the illusion you put him in it took half an hour before he was sure of what was real and what wasn't."

"Precisely why I'm being more delicate," Rich replied. "Shouldn't be much longer now and their relaxing little vacation will have to come to an end."

\* \* \*

Mary gagged as the crushing pressure bore down on her windpipe. The powerful hands yanked her into the air and let her dangle, her small feet kicking helplessly as she tried to quell the rising sense of panic. This wasn't real. She didn't even need air, so choking shouldn't matter. That thought was little comfort as she felt a burning sensation begin to creep across her chest. She groped behind her, searching for anything tender that was in her reach. Her nails brushed something she thought was skin and Mary drove her fingernails in with every ounce of strength she could muster.

There was a grunt of pain and suddenly Mary felt like she was flying. She realized a moment before impact that her attacker had released one hand and was using the other to hurl her down in a choke slam. Her backbone struck the wooden top of a pew and Mary lost most of her precious remaining air in a gasp of pain. If she'd been in her real body she was certain there would have been breaks in her spine. Her head swam, red dots blurring her vision. When they finally cleared, she could see the face of the person pinning her down on the unpadded slab of oak.

"You fucking bitch." Nick spat the words as he glared down at her, but it wasn't a Nick Mary had ever seen before. This wasn't goofy Nick pretending to be dumber than he was. This wasn't casino Nick, master of his environment and all he surveyed. This Nick had a face twisted in hate and anger, his eyes burning with a dark golden light and three slashes of blood trailing down his cheek. All that was scary, but the thing that terrified Mary the most was the shaky way he was clutching her throat. Nick was always in control, always able to stay detached. For the first time she'd ever seen it looked like his emotions were overtaking him, and these weren't emotions she wanted to see play out. Mary felt the panic rise again; she began to claw uselessly at his hand.

"What fucking right do you have? I tolerate your intrusions, I bear your nosy nature, and you decide those acts of civility mean you're free to look at any damned part of me you want."

Mary opened her mouth, wondering if she had enough breath left for even one response. She didn't find out; Nick jerked her up and slammed her back to the wood, smashing her head and leaving her mouth with the taste of blood.

"Don't you fucking say a word. I don't want to hear it. This is too much. There's no going back from this one, Mary." His grip grew even tighter. Mary wondered if he was really this strong or if it was simply because he made the rules down here. She was curious what would happen if she died like this. Would a part of her stay gone when she awoke, some piece of her mind eternally obliterated? Maybe she wouldn't wake up at all. Rich would get blamed, Nick would walk away free. If she didn't know better she'd swear he'd planned it all to work out that way.

"Stop it!" The younger version of Nick leapt onto the arm pinning Mary down and began trying to wrestle it away. "Don't hurt her!"

Nick's face flickered with uncertainty. It made sense: here he was

literally fighting with himself. That was bound to cause some confusion. “Why do you care?”

“I don’t want to hurt anyone else I care about.” Young Nick was crying again, but his voice was determined and his efforts to free her unyielding.

“Her?”

“She’s my friend.”

“You don’t have friends,” Nick barked. Mary wasn’t sure, but it seemed like his shoulders sagged a bit. “We don’t have friends.” Nick shook his head. “I don’t have friends. Friends are for marks. All I have is the family.”

“She’s our friend,” young Nick said, staring his older version in the eyes. “Now please, let her go.”

Nick looked at the two of them, the golden burning in his eyes subsiding to reveal their usual brown irises. He slowly relaxed his hand and Mary nearly vomited as she gulped air down gluttonously. She fell to the ground, coughing and wheezing as her body began coming back to life. As she lay there, Mary made a mental note not to die by asphyxiation. There had to be more pleasant ways to go.

Eventually she regained enough strength to rise, getting to her feet and seeing that both Nicks were standing in front of the coffins. The older one was hugging the younger one close, like a big brother trying to squeeze in some semblance of comfort. Mary couldn’t remember if she’d ever seen Nick hug anyone before. She walked forward gently, not sure of what to say to the man who’d just been on the verge of crushing her windpipe.

“This never happened, you know.” Nick’s voice echoed through the church, reaching Mary easily even as he faced away from her.

“What didn’t?”

“All of this.” Nick made a broad, sweeping gesture. “I mean, there was a funeral, of course. I just wasn’t in attendance. They insisted on keeping me at the hospital for several weeks after the accident.”

“Wait, you were in that?” Mary came closer and stared at the hunk of metal. The idea that anything could have walked away from it was beyond mind-boggling.



“I was. They couldn’t believe I’d gotten through without some sort of damage, so the doctors had me under strict observation for some time.”

“That’s still terrible, not letting you say goodbye to your parents.”

Nick shrugged. “Given that I was only four months old at the time, I guess they figured I wouldn’t really know the difference.”

“Four months old? What about him?”

“He’s the age I was when I realized what had happened.”

Mary shuffled awkwardly. There was only one place to take this conversation, but even though he knew that she knew, it still felt like speaking the words aloud would be an act that could change everything. She decided to press on as carefully as possible.

“He seemed to think you had something to do with the accident.”

“I probably did. In all likelihood I’m the reason my parents are dead.” His voice was hollow as it cascaded through the room.

“You were a baby, Nick; you couldn’t have caused something like that.”

Nick turned around slowly and looked at her; his lean face seemed almost gaunt in the wavering light of the candles. For the barest instant his eyes sparked golden. “Couldn’t I?”

Mary felt a horrible, wrenching sensation as she put it all together. An accident that ravaged the vehicle, with only one miraculous survivor. The way the car resembled the wreckage that had once been the truck George tried to kidnap her in. Nick’s ability to manipulate luck, and what his life had been like back when he was a Powered. What it must have been like, always wondering if the reason you’d grown up an orphan was because of some awful curse that genetics or God had cast upon you.

“That’s the memory you were looking for. You wanted to see if it was really you who caused the crash.”

Nick raised an eyebrow. “How did you know that?”

“Gerry told me.”

“That actually raises more questions than it answers.” Nick shook his head. “Never mind, I think I’d rather not know for now. It doesn’t matter; as

soon as I felt you here I came running.”

“Nick, most people never show any symptoms of their abilities until three or four at the very earliest.”

“Most.”

The single word said volumes. Rather than continuing any debate, Mary walked the rest of the way to the front and wrapped her arms around the tall boy’s torso.

“What are you doing?”

“Hugging you.”

“Ah. Why?”

“Because I can’t think of any other way to make you feel better.”

“Thank you.” These words came from young Nick, the first he’d spoken since the altercation.

“Yes, thank you, I suppose,” Nick echoed. “And I guess I’m sorry for my reaction.”

“Don’t worry about it. The way I see it you only imagined trying to kill me, and it would be pretty unfair of me to hold a grudge against your imagination.”

When they woke up minutes later there would be much to talk about, things that would be conveyed through read thoughts and covert nods. For now, for only this moment, there was peace, and in this room, through that door, down this hall, peace was something that hadn’t been present in a very long time.

## 64.

Alice's mouth felt dry. She blinked her eyes, nearly overwhelmed by the red lighting and loud music. Things had been so quiet only seconds ago.

"I think she's coming out of it." The voice was female and familiar. Alice turned and saw tussled blonde hair atop a curious expression. "Here, drink this. The others said they had some wicked cotton mouth." The girl held out a glass of clear liquid, presumably water.

"Thanks," Alice mumbled. She accepted the offering, surprising at how cold it was to the touch. With two gulps she'd drained its contents and began shaking off the jumbled feeling in her head. She looked over and realized why the voice had sounded familiar. The girl it belonged to was Jill. She and Will were sitting at the booth with her, the others nowhere to be seen.

"What happened?"

"It seems our teammate, Rich, took some offense to Nick's questioning of his skills, thus he decided a demonstration was in order. You have our sincerest apologies," Will said in his usual crisp tones.

"Right," Alice said, staring at the table as things began to mentally realign. "Right, he put us in a dream."

"It's a bit more complex than that: a lucid hallucination would be a better term. But for current intents and purposes, yes, he put you in a dream," Will explained.

Alice nodded. It was all coming back to her: Nick's insults, the spa, the pedicure.

Abridail.

Jill didn't notice, but Will saw Alice's grip on the table suddenly tighten, her knuckles beginning to go white. She turned her face up and forced a contorted, half-mad smile.

"And where is Rich?"

"He's with the others. They all went to the bar to get drinks. We volunteered to sit here and keep an eye on you," Jill supplied helpfully.

"Thank you." Alice rose from the table and began slicing her way

through the room.

“Where-” Jill’s question was cut off as Will put a hand on her shoulder.

“Don’t. Let her go. Also, interrupt the security camera footage in this place if you can.”

“Why?”

“Because I’m afraid whatever she’s about to do is the sort of incident none of us want captured on film,” Will said cryptically.

Jill got the message and began working to kill the surveillance. She managed it nearly a full minute before things went completely batshit.

\* \* \*

Everyone had just finished getting their drinks when Alice found the cluster. Vince and Selena noticed her approaching, but only Alex and Mary got any forewarning of what was about to happen. Even with that, neither had enough time to both process what was emanating from Alice’s white hot mind and react to stop her.

“Yeah, holding it isn’t that hard,” Rich said, he and Nick absorbed in discussion about the finer points of his talents. “Setting it up is the only part that takes much effort. After that it’s not much worse than-”

“YOU BASTARD!” Alice swung with all her might, cracking Rich squarely in the jaw and sending him tumbling to the floor. He was numb in surprise, trying to sort out what had just happened, when the toe of a red heel drove itself forcefully into his stomach.

“Do you think that’s funny? Do you think that’s FUCKING FUNNY?!” Alice’s voice spiked as she reared back for another kick. She felt someone pulling her back by the shoulders, noticed the stares of all the strangers around her, and proceeded willfully to not give any semblance of a fuck. She struggled forward and mustered all her power into one last blow. The hands holding her were strong, but in that moment Alice was a focused inferno just begging for release. Her long, elegant model leg slammed its foot into Rich’s ribs. There was a sickening crack from his torso; however, it was lost in the enormous crashing sound that filled the room.

Every suspended light within twenty feet of Alice came plummeting down simultaneously, shattering on the ground and sending the costumed

partiers into a panic. Alice tried to get in one more shot in the confusion, her own mind not even registering the event; however, she found Chad suddenly standing in front of her. He didn't make any movements to touch her, but it was evident anything she sent at Rich would be blocked. With the bulk of her rage spent and her target cut off from her, Alice finally felt the emotional weight she'd been trying to push back. The blonde girl in the devil costume slumped and began to cry soundlessly. She turned and collapsed into the shoulder of one of the people who'd been pulling her back, shaking gently as she lost her last shred of control.

"Nick, Vince, get Alice some fresh air outside. We'll catch up in a minute," Mary ordered. The two boys obeyed without comment. Even Nick was quiet, though whether it was the intensity of the situation or the tall blonde weeping freely on his chest that stayed his tongue was anyone's guess. He and the silver-haired vampire gently escorted her out the door. Few people noticed her sobbing in the still-bubbling confusion, and those that did assumed she'd been struck by one of the lights.

Mary turned her attention to Rich, who was trying to lift himself from the ground while favoring his damaged ribs. Camille stepped forward and reached out; Mary saw in her thoughts that she was going to heal him.

"Don't help him," Mary snapped. She had to make a conscious effort not to ball her hands into fists. She didn't need to lose her temper, too. They'd drawn far too much attention as it was; one more curious event could get them noticed in the wrong way and booted from the HCP.

"What the fuck was her problem?" Rich had blood on his teeth, probably from Alice's first punch.

"Rich, I heard Alice's thoughts when she was attacking you. I know what went on in her dream. Now, the reason I sent Nick and Vince out of the room is because if they knew too I'm afraid they might genuinely try to kill you."

Rich stared up at her, the rest of his team involuntarily stepping closer to him. They were a unit, after all. That was fine; Mary didn't need to settle this here and now. She only needed confirmation.

"I'm going to tell you what she was mad about, and so help me God, if Alex or I pick up one mental twinge that you had something to do with it I'll make you regret the day you set foot on Lander Campus." Mary took a breath and tried again to claim herself down. "In Alice's dream she was approached

by a man she didn't know, who told her that he was a friend of her mother's."

"I don't see the issue here," Chad said, trying to curtail the escalating situation.

"Alice's mother died when she was a baby. Yet this man, this stranger who appeared in the scenario Rich constructed for her, said she was still alive, and very much wanted to see her daughter."

A burst of panic tore through Rich's mind. It was a sensation heavy with fear, but the fear wasn't of Mary or Alex. She wondered what scared him more than a pair of righteously pissed off telekinetics. She didn't have to wonder long.

"I swear, I had nothing to do with that. I just stuck her in her subconscious. I didn't add anything!" Rich objected furiously. Flecks of blood and spit flew from his mouth as he protested his innocence. His mind supported the story; there was shock and uncertainty at what could have gone awry.

Mary looked at Alex. "Anything?" Alex said nothing, but thought the word *No*. Mary turned back to see Chad hauling Rich to his feet.

"I'm very sorry for whatever Alice experienced," Chad said calmly. "I hope you've seen that Rich had nothing to do with it, at least not intentionally. We are all still learning, and it's possible for mistakes to be made."

"As far as we can tell he didn't know about it," Mary confirmed.

"Good," Chad said, resting his hand on Rich's shoulder. "Because I'm certain no member of my team would intentionally do anything as horrible as playing on the emotional wounds of someone who had lost a parent." Mary heard another cluster of fear-soaked thoughts scatter through Rich's brain. She noticed that while Chad's hand might seem to be there for support, his fingers were digging rather forcefully into his teammate's shoulder. Given how strong Chad was, Mary had to imagine that was pretty painful.

"I can absolutely assure you that such a thing will never happen again, be it accident or otherwise," Chad continued, his tone still perfectly neutral. Mary couldn't read his mind, and she didn't have Nick's talents for seeing through people, but it was still plain as day in that moment that Chad knew exactly the same kind of pain as Alice. She hoped that Rich really was innocent as Chad believed him to be; otherwise he was likely in for a pretty horrible couple of hours.

“We should probably go,” Alex pointed out, breaking the discussion between captains. “We can still slip out like we’re scared, but if we stay much longer people are going to start asking about the fight.”

“He’s right,” Chad concurred. “Let’s call it a night.”

Mary agreed, and the group broke into clusters of twos and threes then headed for the doors. Rich tried to get alongside Camille, but Chad’s guiding hand kept him directly next to his captain. Together the boys headed out into the cold night. Everyone dispersed except for Mary, Camille, and Hershel, who found the two boys and Alice at the side of the black brick building. Together they piled into cars and headed toward home, finally ending what had amounted to another quite shitty Halloween.

## 65.

“Sounds like quite an eventful night,” Mr. Numbers said. He studied the board for a moment and then moved his pawn.

“That’s one heck of an understatement,” Mary replied. Her eyes swept over each piece as she contemplated possible moves. “When we got home, Alice barely stayed awake long enough for Camille to heal her hand. She passed out on the couch; poor thing was completely wiped. I had to carry her into her room.”

“How nice of you.”

“To be honest, I was a little thankful she fell asleep. I didn’t even know what to say to her at the time. Plus I was drained from some... other stuff.” Mary moved her rook a few spaces up. She’d lose it in two moves, but if she was lucky, it would give her an opening.

“Other stuff?” Mr. Numbers moved his bishop, setting his own trap for when Mary attempted to spring the one she was haphazardly constructing.

“Yeah, other stuff.” Mary and Nick had shared some brief words, mostly agreement that what had been seen in his mind was to stay between the two of them. Other than that, he had kept his distance for the rest of the evening. Of course, Alice had needed tending to, and in her distraught state she’d barely released Nick for any extended period of time. Still, Mary had a feeling she would need to have a talk with her sunglasses-sporting teammate before long. What she’d learned was simply too huge not to affect their friendship. That would come in time; currently she had bigger concerns.

Mr. Numbers watched Mary move a pawn, sealing the outcome of the game. He’d have her in five moves. “So, have you talked to her about the other aspect of the incident?”

Mary shook her head. “She’s been asleep, or pretending to be asleep, all morning. I’m not even sure what we do about it.”

“You should talk to the dean. He’ll direct you to the appropriate course. I assure you, Supers discovering new aspects of their abilities is hardly unheard of in the HCP.” Mr. Numbers moved his bishop.

“I guess so. She might want to keep it secret for a little while, at least until she gets a handle on it.” Mary moved another pawn quickly, hoping to



step up the pace of the game and lure him into a mistake.

“Trust me, if the dean isn’t already aware of Alice’s new light-smashing developments, he will be soon. The man runs a tight ship and has been actively keeping an eye on you five.”

“Is that your way of saying you’ll tell him if we don’t?”

“Yes.”

Mary cocked an eyebrow. It was rare to get such a straightforward answer from Mr. Numbers.

“That seems a bit like prying into our business.”

“Mr. Transport and I are your caretakers. Prying is one of the main parts of the job description.” Mr. Numbers moved his own knight, taking Mary’s rook. “That said, I would report this information even if it wasn’t about one of our charges. Alice needs to get training and she needs it as soon as possible. For a regular Super or a Powered, an uncontrolled ability is already dangerous, but for someone in the HCP it is utterly unacceptable.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Mary agreed. “We do tend to be a bit more active with our powers. I can see how Alice might hurt someone without meaning to.” Mary sent her rook into the fray, taking one of Mr. Numbers’ pawns in the process.

“Someone, or herself,” Mr. Numbers added.

“Fine, you’ve made your point. How would I even reach him on a Saturday?”

“I have a number you can call to set up an appointment.” Mr. Numbers moved his queen into position, preparing for the final blow.

“I’ll get Alice and call after the game is over,” Mary said.

“Then I suggest you get the phone. We don’t have long to go.”

“Don’t go counting me out until it’s over.”

She was beaten in two more moves. Mr. Numbers cleared the board while Mary went to attend to the undesirable task of dragging Alice out of bed. She wasn’t surprised, not really. She never came close to beating Mr. Numbers. It was as impossible as beating Roy in an arm wrestling contest. Mary wisely understood that losing could still teach a person quite a bit, so

she persisted in her weekly habit of being clobbered despite any sense of progress. Mr. Numbers occasionally opined that such persistence was one of the habits that made her a good leader and might one day make her a good Hero. If he being truly honest with himself, he might have admitted that these thoughts were actually less opinion than they were hope; however, Mr. Numbers was seldom that honest with anyone, especially himself.

\* \* \*

Alice lay in her bed, staring at the ceiling. She was trying to sleep; however, her body had expelled her from dreamland some hours earlier and was having none of her attempts to gain re-entry. She wanted to fall back into blissful slumber because she knew that once her feet left the covers, her day had to begin. She would need to talk to the professors about the crashing lights, because while she was skeptical she had the ability to do something like that, it seemed far too big of a coincidence to ignore. She'd probably have to find Rich and apologize at some point; Mary and Alex had confirmed that whatever had gone on in her mind probably wasn't created by him. Alice had heard the words at the time, but they couldn't register until after she'd calmed down. She might owe Nick a new shirt: she was fairly certain the makeup she'd had on would stain most materials when combined with tears.

All of these were reasons she was still on her back despite the slowly rising sun, but they weren't the main one. In her heart of hearts, the reason Alice didn't want to get up is that once she accepted this new day, her mother would be dead again. She'd had a brief taste of hope and it had soured the whole of reality for her. It wasn't surprising that her psyche would dream up something as twisted as a mysterious stranger telling her that her mother was actually alive. Not surprising, but exasperating. Yet here she was, still clinging on to that little piece of her that wanted to believe that somehow it was true. That part would evaporate when she got up. There was no room for such childish delusions in the cold wastelands of the real world.

There was a soft knock on her door. "Alice, are you up yet?" It was Mary. Of course it was Mary. She was coming by to check on her, to help make things right. That was what Mary did. Alice said nothing, just kept staring at the ceiling.

"We've got an appointment with Dean Blaine in an hour. I'll come back in fifteen minutes, but if you're still asleep, I'll have to wake you up." There was a sound of footsteps walking away, barely discernible through the thick door.

Alice wondered how she'd make good on that threat. Could she levitate the bed without seeing it? Maybe she'd have Mr. Transport teleport her in here. She'd find a way; Alice had no doubt of that. The alarm clock was blinking ten o'clock. That meant they needed to be in the office at eleven. She could keep wasting time here and throw herself together at the last minute, or she could get up and put on her armor. Mascara, blush, eye shadow, heels, straightened hair, an hour of effort to appear as if she were effortlessly beautiful. Alice didn't need all of that; she was naturally gorgeous. She did it because it made her feel stronger, like she had some control over the world around her. She needed to feel stronger today. She needed it very badly.

Alice swung her feet over the edge of her bed and plopped onto the floor. She winced, ever so slightly, and then set about getting ready for the day ahead.

## 66.

Roy was in the gym. He'd planned on taking some time off from training, but after Friday's little burst of craziness, he wasn't able to resist. He lifted the weights, ultra dense circles specifically designed for people like Roy. They made it possible to really push oneself without having to go to a train yard or other such place.

Roy finished his set of bicep curls and grabbed a pair of weights one increment heavier. Roy took a deep breath, focused with all his will, and began to lift. The weights made it halfway up before his arms gave out. There was a thunderous crunching sound as they shattered the concrete beneath his feet.

"Damn it!" Roy resisted the urge to drive his fist into the wall, but only because of the throbbing pain already coming from his biceps. This was bullshit. He'd hit this wall over a month ago and he'd been trying to break through it since. It made no sense; he'd tripled the number of reps he could do just one weight unit lower but he still couldn't get even one lift at the higher level. It was like his body had reached a limit and no matter what he did, it wasn't willing to budge. Roy was growing concerned that this was as far as his power could go. It was a fear that had become stronger with each failed attempt.

Seeing Alice's spectacle had both inspired and terrified him. It gave him hope that maybe he had some ability that had yet to be discovered, but it also made him wonder if he was getting passed up by the others. Alice had some new skill, Vince had grown by leaps and bounds, Mary had always been stronger than he was, and it turned out Nick had been concealing a rapier intellect. All Roy could do was punch hard. He'd been okay with that, too; it was a skill that was always in demand. If he couldn't get stronger than this, however, then it was only a matter of time until he started to become useless. He hadn't been able to hurt George, and he doubted that had changed despite his progress. There were others out there, people even stronger than his former kidnapping coach. A Hero with Roy's power needed to be able to play on their level, a level that Roy seemed banned from.

He let his arms heal for a moment, then moved on to the bench press. There was another wall here, and on the shoulders, the legs, everything really. Roy was spinning his wheels, and he couldn't think of any way to get traction

again. He pressed on regardless, if only because of an unspoken hope that soon he'd push just hard enough to break through.

That hope was getting dimmer by the day.

\* \* \*

"You'll find their complete recollections of the incident in the packets, along with some footage I confiscated from a few cell phones," Dean Blaine said, sliding the manila envelope across his desk. Professor Hill picked it up and scanned through it quickly; there were only a few documents along with a USB drive taped to the inner back of the envelope.

"Confiscated, huh? Told them they'd accidentally caught something classified, I assume."

"Something like that."

"How kind of you, especially considering that what happened could almost be looked at as a violation of the secret identity rule," Professor Hill pointed out.

Dean Blaine raised an eyebrow. "You have an objection?"

"Not at all, you know that. I'm just bringing up a point that someone else will raise eventually."

"If they did, I would simply remind them that the rule is designed to keep our students in line when dealing with regular humans, not punish them for having the misfortune to make a discovery about their abilities while in public. Ms. Adair's ferocious beating of Mr. Weaver aside, she didn't intend for the gravity spasm to occur. She's never experienced anything like it before and couldn't have intentionally summoned it if she tried."

"Gravity manipulation," Professor Hill said, turning his eyes back to the file. "Given her genetics I always suspected that's where her flight came from."

"Hope is not the same thing as suspicion," Dean Blaine corrected. "Besides, nothing is confirmed yet. It could be an aspect of Mr. Weaver's abilities that manifested in distress."

Professor Hill snorted. "Yeah, right. We both know that's unlikely. He did have good reason to be distressed, I'll say that. I'm surprised by how much damage she did. Maybe you need to pull her from Subtlety and stick her

in Close Combat.”

“Mmm, I’m sure you’d like to see me redistribute the bulk of Professor Pendleton’s students in such a fashion.”

“You and I both know that specialty is all trouble. The last person you had teaching it was an undercover kidnapper, and the most qualified person to replace her is a convict. I think that says it all.”

“Subtlety walks a dangerous line, I won’t disagree with you on that. Not all of the Heroes who turn to crime have their concentration in it, however. Raze and George were both specialized in Close Combat, and Globe got his HCP major in Control, just like you.”

“Three examples. The mass of them still come from Subtlety.”

“Subtlety is an established part of the HCP agenda. I have neither the power nor the inclination to remove it. As for Professor Pendleton, I heard your objections when I offered him the job. They were weighed and considered before I made my decision. Now I’d suggest you worry less about his class and more about how you’ll assist your own student.”

“Whatever you say, Boss. I’ll start by helping her figure out how to access that part of her ability. What did Rich do to piss her off so much, anyway?”

Dean Blaine hesitated. He needed to approach this carefully, given Professor Hill’s sensitivities. “He sealed her, along with Mr. Campbell and Ms. Smith, in their minds to prove a point. Ms. Adair experienced a rather upsetting vision while so incapacitated and thought Mr. Weaver had inflicted it on her purposely. All current investigations point to that not being the case, so at the end of the day it was a simple misunderstanding that got out of hand.”

“What was her vision?”

“I believe it was something about her mother. A false hope her brain cobbled together. Completely understandable given her past.” Dean Blaine watched Professor Hill carefully, eyes searching for any signs of repressed anger. He saw an initial flare-up, which simmered down as reason stepped in.

“I see. And we’re sure it wasn’t Rich?”

“Multiple telepaths confirmed he was surprised by the revelation,” Dean Blaine replied.

“Well, I don’t think I’ll use that route for training, but it’s good to know at least.” Professor Hill rose from his seat. “She’s expecting to stay after class on Monday, right?”

“Correct.”

“Good. Thanks for the heads up and everything,” Professor Hill said, clutching the file tightly in his hand.

“Thank you for coming in to meet on a weekend,” Dean Blaine replied. Professor Hill gave a curt nod and exited, leaving the dean alone to wonder just what those Melbrook students would throw at him next.

## 67.

Monday brought, along with an extra class for Alice, a pre-class gathering for all the sophomores. They clustered together in the gym, milling about while the teachers took their damned sweet time in making whatever announcement was pending. Most already suspected that they knew the subject matter: given that they'd just crested the hill into November, the only pertinent thing looming was midterms. After last year's labyrinth, the room was rife with rumor on what waited for them before the winter break. Some believed it would be a team match pitting them against a professor. Others speculated it would be a solo endeavor featuring grueling mental and physical punishment. Most assumed it would at least suck, and the ones who didn't were among the few who hadn't yet been significantly challenged by any of the tests the HCP had presented. The one thing none of them were expecting was what turned out to be the truth.

"Good morning, everyone," Dean Blaine said, stepping forward with the six professors at his rear. "I just had a quick announcement to make. I'm sure most of you are wondering when your midterms will be. Well, as far as the HCP goes, there will not be any."

He was met with untrusting stares, too certain of deception to even bother with murmuring. It was understandable; the HCP wasn't exactly known for its easygoing policies.

"I can see you're all skeptical. While that's a good thing, in this case it's unwarranted. You see we don't do midterms for sophomores for a few reasons. First off, the midterms for students in the other years are very time-consuming to set up - so much so that adding a fourth to our schedule would likely be impossible. Secondly, all the team events that sophomores participate in give us ample data for evaluation; adding a test in the middle of the year wouldn't make much difference either way. It would be a poor use of time and resources, so enjoy the free pass. It will be the only year you receive it, and I expect your grades in other classes to pick up proportionately. That will be all."

The chorus of whispers Dean Blaine had been expecting finally materialized when he turned his back. They still wouldn't accept it for a while, and a few would spend the next month and a half waiting for a surprise test that would never come. Hopefully they'd put this free time to good use;



heaven knows they wouldn't get many more opportunities like this in the coming years. Free time dissolved after year two, the rest of college whipping by in a blur until there were only a few weeks until the final hurdle to graduation. Year two was the last time they'd really get to stop and catch their breath, and when they did, they'd find their chests had grown tight with fear, paralyzed with a crippling terror of what would happen if they failed – one that would only grow stronger the nearer they drew to their goal.

\* \* \*

Blaine stood out on the balcony, wishing he could smoke. He'd burned a few in high school, but that habit had gotten squashed out of him after his first week in the HCP. The workouts were hard enough without a diminished lung capacity. His fingers still itched for a cigarette, especially when he was stressed or had the taste of bourbon in his mouth. He wondered if the cravings would ever completely go away. They said it happened eventually, but "they" said a lot of things that turned out to be bullshit.

Blaine heard the door open behind him and felt the cool air waft out from the apartment. Clarissa's place had an amazing view, but the price was standing in the unseasonable heat. It was still early summer, yet Blaine was certain he'd sweated through his shirt and that only his suit jacket was concealing the shame. He wondered if that's why a jacket was part of such fancy ensembles in the first place.

"Man, you've got the right idea. I need a little fresh air; that place is too loud and stuffy." Blaine knew the voice instantly, as he knew every voice in attendance that night. All of them belonged to his classmates in the HCP, all save for one. It was the unique voice that he knew best of all, and that voice was part of why he stood on the balcony suppressing a craving instead of socializing with everyone else.

Fortunately, his new companion was not the owner of that voice. This one belonged to Joshua, who came to the railing and looked over the city with him.

"Hard to believe in a few weeks we'll all be going in different directions," Joshua remarked.

"Mmhmm."

"Any idea who you'll be apprenticing under?"

"There aren't any official offers made until after graduation," Blaine

pointed out.

“Come on, man, you and I both know you’ll be one of the ten. You can’t tell me you haven’t gotten a few feelers already.”

“There may have been some inquiries. Genogong and Grey Earl have been particularly persistent,” Blaine admitted.

“Wow, those two are pretty impressive,” Joshua complimented. “All I’ve gotten so far is a vague interest from Shade Slime.”

“More will come after the test,” Blaine assured him.

“Maybe. I’m not exactly the most impressive of our lot, power-wise.” Joshua said this with an easygoing smile that never seemed to leave his lips. It was the truth, but only because of the tremendous crop of talent their class had yielded. Besides, what Joshua might lack in showmanship, he made up for in reliability and charm. He had knack for turning everyone into a friend, and given the competitiveness of their environment, that was almost more useful than his actual power.

“I’m positive you’ll get a solid offer,” Blaine said. “I can’t imagine anyone underestimating you once they see what you can do.”

“I’ll hope for the best, that’s all any of us can do.” Joshua pulled a flask from his own jacket pocket. He carefully unscrewed the top and offered the container to Blaine. “Care for a nip? I know you prefer bourbon to the wine Clarissa stocked.”

Blaine didn’t bother asking why he would have a flask of that brand on hand; the answer was evident. It was to appease the woman Joshua had come with, the one who Blaine had introduced to this beverage in the first place. He accepted the flask and took a short draw.

“Thank you.”

“My pleasure,” Joshua said, taking his own sip. He swished it around as he debated how to broach the subject on his mind. Eventually he decided the straightforward route was the best option. “Look, not to make this uncomfortable or anything, but I just wanted to make sure you and I are cool.”

Blaine bit back a scathing retort and soothed his temper. He didn’t have any right to act that way, not when Joshua had been so honest and forthright with him from the beginning. “Of course we are. Miriam and I

broke up over three years ago. I'm glad the two of you have found happiness with one another."

"I appreciate that," Joshua replied. "I really like dating her; I think we might have a future together. Let me know if it gets awkward, okay? I don't have to bring her to all our events if it makes you uncomfortable."

"I will make certain to tell you if that becomes an issue." Blaine would cut out his own tongue before he'd actually let it speak those words.

"Cool," Joshua said, taking another sip from the flask. "Cool."

"Did Gerard have any trouble scrubbing the stain from the tea out?" Blaine was unabashedly changing the subject. He'd had a small incident during Clarissa's serving ceremony which resulted in him spilling tea on Gerard's pants. He'd said it was because of the heat of the cup, but the truth was he'd seen Miriam grab Joshua's thigh. In that instant his coordination had simply deserted him.

"He got most of it; I think a good dry-cleaner can fix the rest," Joshua told him. "Once you do graduate maybe your Hero name should be Butterfingers."

"Or The Fumbler."

"Spilltacular," Joshua said with a chuckle. Blaine laughed too, if only because he couldn't really think of anything else to do. "On that note, have you given any thought to your actual Hero name? We'll have to register them right after the White Cape ceremony."

"I've got a couple of ideas I've been kicking around. You?"

"Honestly? I've got an idea, but I keep waffling back and forth on if I should come up with something better."

"You've still got a month," Blaine said.

"True. Hopefully I'll find some inspiration. Tell me one of yours, maybe it will get the creative juices flowing."

"Well, I haven't found one that seems perfect yet, but there are a few near the top. For example, you know how my ability affects an area around my body?"

"Yeah."

“I was thinking of doing a play on that,” Blaine explained. “At first I considered Radius or Sphere, but those sounded too mathematical. Then one day I was sitting in class and it hit me. The perfect name for how my power encircles me: Globe.”

## 68.

Thomas hunched over his kitchen table, a large piece of paper with multiple written entries to his side and a laptop directly in front of him. His other roommates were there as well, their own checklists present, however they had not brought out personal computers.

“Okay,” Thomas said with a deep breath. “So we’ve found a good deal on some kegs, we’ve located a place two towns over that sells plastic cups in bulk, and we’ve alerted our neighbors to the impending disturbance. What’s next?”

“Food,” Stella replied.

“We have to feed them too?” Will asked.

“You guys really haven’t been to many parties,” Violet commented. It was one point that she mentioned at least once an hour. She’d been shocked when Thomas told her he’d been tasked with throwing the party the freshmen were invited to, and even more floored when he said he’d decided to do it. Despite having dated him for a few months, there were times when Violet felt she never really knew her tan-skinned friend. He’d approached it with his usual meticulous voracity, and now that they didn’t have a midterm to worry about, it seemed like they’d be able to get it on track in a matter of weeks.

“Food is there to help people sober up if they overshoot their limits,” Violet explained. “You make it things like pretzels and bread to help soak up the booze.”

“That’s actually a common myth,” Will corrected. “Food existing in the stomach before alcohol is introduced can affect the rate of absorption; however, once the alcohol has been ingested, new food would have no discernible effect. It is simple biology.”

“Fair enough, but you just said yourself it’s a commonly held myth, right?” Violet asked.

“Indeed.”

“Then people who believe it will help calm their stomachs and make them less intoxicated could very likely see those effects since they’re expecting them. Same as sugar pills in place of painkillers.”

“Ah, you’re referencing the Placebo Effect.”

“It is simple psychology.”

“Point taken,” Will said. Other men of his intelligence might have balked at being bested by a girl who specialized in brawn over brains, but Will had long ago learned that intelligence in one area didn’t make him infallible in others. He was a mechanic: he looked at the body like a machine and often forgot the less tangible components the mind could present. “I believe we can get sandwiches from The Mayo Hut at a sizable discount thanks to the owner’s infatuation with my sister.”

“Pimping your own sister to the cause, that’s dedication.” Stella said.

“It is something of a family tradition to place one another in uncomfortable positions,” Will replied. “Besides, with as much patronage as she gives that establishment, I’d think it only good business to provide her preferential treatment.”

“Jill does love her sandwiches,” Thomas agreed. “So we’ll let her take care of that and I can pick up a few jumbo bags of pretzels from the same place from which we’re getting the cups.” Thomas scratched a long line through one of the items on his paper as Will jotted down the details of his new task. “What’s next?”

“Guest list,” Violet said.

Thomas shook his head. “I don’t think we pick and choose. I’ll just spread the word through the freshmen and anyone who is brave enough to show up is welcome. That’s how Angela did it and I feel it worked quite well.”

“I’d agree, but I wasn’t talking about the freshmen.” Violet looked at her friends and carefully framed her next words. “Look, there’s a bit of an elephant in the room here that none of us has brought up. We need to talk about it. Are we going to invite the Powered’s to this thing?”

“They’re not-”

“I know they aren’t, Thomas, but you get what I mean.”

“I thought we agreed at the beginning of the year to treat them with the same friendship they’ve shown us,” Thomas pointed out. Stella and Will nodded in agreement.

“We did, and I still think we should, but despite the fact that we’re throwing it, this party isn’t really about us. It’s about the freshmen, and introducing them to the Lander community as a whole.”

“All the more reason to show them that we are accepting of people who may come from different backgrounds than ourselves,” Thomas rebutted. “We will set the standard for them to look to.”

“We are accepting - ‘we’ being the key word,” Violet said, softening her voice so as not to seem aggressive. “Not everyone else is, and they may not want to socialize with people who started life as Powered. It’s prejudiced and ignorant, but there’s a lot of unspoken dislike and hate for those five even if we choose to ignore it. Now, if this were just us putting together a shindig, I’d say fuck ‘em if they don’t like our friends. But again, this is about the freshmen, and what impression do you think they’ll take from a party populated solely by the people who live in the house and the school’s pariahs?”

“She makes a valid point,” Will said. “We’re supposed to be bringing them into the larger community of Supers. Inviting the residents of Melbrook could very well limit that community.”

“I don’t like it, but I think I understand your concern,” Thomas admitted. “So what’s the right thing to do?”

“I’m not sure,” Violet replied. “That’s why I brought it up. It seems like either decision is morally wrong in some aspect.”

The four sat silently in contemplation for a few moments. Each was lost in a maelstrom of their own ethical quandaries, a tornado of possible decisions and uncertainty. Curiously, it was Stella who provided the insight that allowed them to move forward.

“You know, you guys keep talking about how we’re bringing them into the Super community, but that’s not actually true,” Stella said, breaking the kitchen’s unhappy silence. “We’re not Supers, and we’re not a community of Supers. We’re a community of future Heroes. Of course not all of us will make it, but all of us are striving to earn the title. Heroes don’t cave to the pressures of hate. Heroes do what’s right, no matter what. So what if some people don’t show up? I say it’s more important to set the example of acceptance even when, no, especially when it’s an unpopular decision.”

“That was... surprisingly eloquent,” Will said, mustering his own words through the fog of surprise.

“I gots my moments,” Stella quipped back.

“Right then; we invite everyone in our class, no exceptions,” Thomas said. “Agreed?” He received three nearly synchronized nods from his roommates. “Glad that’s settled. Next item of business: plastic sheeting for all the carpeted areas. Anyone have a clue where to get that stuff? Because otherwise I see no way we’ll be getting our security deposit back on this place.”



## 69.

“Professor Fletcher?” The voice came from his office door, which Carl had never gotten in the habit of closing. He felt an open door policy should actually involve an open door. It was one of those pleasantries that seemed to have died away over time, and damn it, if he was going to be stuck in his golden years, he reserved the right to live in the past. Carl glanced up from the paperwork on his desk, a bit surprised to see Roy Daniels standing the doorway.

“Come on in,” he said, giving a curt nod to the chair. Unlike the office’s previous tenant, Professor Fletcher was fastidious in keeping the place straight and minimizing clutter. Roy had no trouble navigating to the chair or dropping into a sitting position. Once there he did seem to have some trouble getting the conversation started. Professor Fletcher found himself curious; the Daniels boy never seemed to feel out of place. This must be something pretty interesting.

“I assume you didn’t just come in here to admire my impressive office.”

“No, sir.” Roy’s gaze was on the old wooden desk in front of him, so he missed the fleeting look of shock that dashed across the professor’s face. He couldn’t remember ever hearing Roy refer to anyone as ‘sir’ before.

“So how can I help you?”

“I’m not sure what’s wrong, not exactly,” Roy said. “But I, well, it seems like I’ve hit a wall.”

“Damn it,” Professor Fletcher said, pulling out a form from the top drawer of his desk. “I wish you physical ability kids would learn to keep your shit under control. Okay, we’ll get a maintenance report in. Tell me where it was, and don’t you dare say it was above ground.”

Roy paused for a moment as the words clicked into place. He wasn’t as smart as Hershel, but he put it together eventually. “No, I mean a figurative wall. With my strength.”

“Ohhh, thank heavens.” Professor Fletcher put the paper away and let out a sigh of relief. He noticed the expression on his student’s face and felt compelled to explain. “Not to belittle your problems, it’s just that those forms

can be a real pain in the ass if any damage occurs outside the HCP facility.”

“Gotcha.”

“So, tell me about this non-literal wall you’ve hit.”

Roy explained about the ceiling of weights he’d been unable to break through, despite months of effort. Professor Fletcher listened attentively, nodding in the right places and keeping all his thoughts to himself. By the end, Roy was feeling more confident, trusting his professor would be able to help him get past this issue in no time at all.

“Sounds like you’ve got a real problem,” Professor Fletcher commented once Roy was done.

“Yes, sir. So what’s the solution?”

“Hell if I know.”

The collapse of Roy’s confidence was as visible as the airborne plummet of a Depression era stockbroker.

“Wait, what?”

“Listen, Roy, do you know how many of your classmates have super strength and durability?”

Roy nodded. “Chad, Violet, Stella, and I have both. Others like Sasha have the enhanced endurance, but aren’t really the same.”

“Very good,” Professor Fletcher said, moderately impressed that the boy actually paid that much attention to his surroundings. “So in just the sophomore class we have four people whose powers produce similar abilities. That said, each of those powers is wholly unique. Violet increasing her density is nothing like the way Stella shifts into steel or Chad continuously renovates his body. That’s three people who at first glance seem to be similar, but would have to approach training and improving themselves in completely different ways. That’s one class, in one college that offers the HCP, in one country, in the world.”

“You’re saying helping me is too hard?”

“I’m saying that each of you little bastards works in your own way. Now, you came to me for help, and I’m going to give you all I can. I just want you to understand upfront that I don’t have all the answers. We’ll try every method I can uncover, but there’s a chance we won’t find the one that helps

you get stronger. Hell, it's perfectly possible that this is simply as powerful as you are able to get."

"Oh." Roy looked like he'd been told his dog had died. Professor Fletcher understood. The young people in this program had worked incredibly hard and progressed beyond what most Supers could ever do. Each one was easily in the top ten percent of his specialty. Unfortunately, that wasn't good enough to be a Hero, and the closer they drew to graduation, more and more of them would discover where their limitations lay. Most would find a barrier they were physically incapable of passing, and it would be one of the hardest things they'd ever have to accept.

"Look, I'm not saying you're dead in the water here. If I can find a way to help you I'll damn sure do it. I just want you to be ready to do a lot of work on your own time."

"I'll work out all day every day, sir."

"That's not what I mean." Professor Fletcher leaned back in his chair. "We talked about why the others are strong. Steel body, ultra density, all that stuff. So what makes you strong?"

"Me, I guess. I mean, when I'm Roy I'm just stronger and tougher."

"Just stronger and tougher," Professor Fletcher repeated. "Roy, the key to improvement is understanding how your power works. I mean every last nuance. I'll give you this much, you seem to have the shift down, but I think there's more to your abilities than just a split personality and a good punch. You need to learn more about yourself. It's the best shot you've got at breaking through this ceiling of yours."

"I'm, um, I'm not really good at that touchy feely stuff. That's more Hershel's rodeo."

"Then work with him. Between the two of you I bet you can figure something out. In the meantime, how about we start going through the basic techniques I'm well acquainted with? Maybe we'll get lucky and hit a functional one right off the bat."

"I'd like to try that."

"Great; come by here when you finish your afternoon classes. We'll work out a schedule that doesn't conflict with my other duties."

"Yes, sir." Roy rose from his seat, the consternation and frustration

evident on his face. Professor Fletcher took those as good signs. You don't get frustrated with things you've given up on. If you still cared enough to get pissed off it meant you still had hope. Hope was the difference between people who accepted their limitations and the ones who surpassed them. Professor Fletcher wasn't sure which one Roy would be in the end, but he was definitely curious to find out.

## 70.

“Fall... the... hell... over.” Alice hissed the words through gritted teeth as she stared at the small particle board table. It was shoddily built and would lean to the side on its own. The weight of it was practically negligible and it couldn’t really be used to support much more than a whisper, let alone functionally hold up anything with tangible mass. Professor Hill had built it himself specifically so it fulfilled all of those specifications. Weak and barely stable was a good starting ground.

“Let’s take a break,” Professor Hill said, handing his pupil a bottle of water. Alice accepted it and took a deep swig. She never would have guessed doing nothing could be so draining. This was her third private training session and she still hadn’t gotten the hang of her new abilities. Sometimes she could send the table tumbling multiple times in a row; other times she’d go for an hour producing not so much as a wobble. Professor Hill had been a surprisingly patient teacher, supportive during her failures as much as her successes. Alice felt she might have given up on the whole endeavor already if not for his encouragement.

“I can’t seem to get it today,” Alice said, gulping down the rest of the bottle and setting it aside.

“That’s okay; I told you on the first day you’re going to have steps back as well as forward until you get a stronger level of control.”

“I remember, it’s just frustrating,” Alice admitted. “By the end of our work Wednesday I could knock it down no problem. Now it’s two days later and I’m getting zilch.”

“It happens to nearly everyone in this situation. You’re still learning the motions. It will get easier once you understand the coordination.”

“You sort of lost me there.”

Professor Hill gave her a reassuring smile. “Look at it like you’re learning a new exercise, like a jab. At first you just blindly slug away on the bag with all you’ve got. Some hits seem to make it move more, some barely get it to wiggle. If you keep punching long enough, you’ll stop paying attention to just the motion of your arm and start noticing other things your body is doing. You’ll feel the tension in your abs, you’ll catch the way your back swivels slightly, even your foot placement will become more obvious.

You'll keep taking in the details and realizing that altering these pieces makes a visible difference in how much the bag moves."

Alice could see what he was saying. When she'd first started doing her defense tapes she'd just been swatting at the air. After a few weeks she had gotten the form down. More than that, she found herself doing it without even focusing.

"So you think once I learn how to do more than just turn it on, once I get the hang of all the factors that affect it, I'll be able to use it more reliably. Right?"

"Succinctly and intelligently put," Professor Hill confirmed. "First you learn the motion, then you learn the system, then you can elevate both to higher levels. So let's get at it."

"Sounds good." Alice turned her attention back to the barely-balanced table and drew together her concentration. She'd tried tapping into her anger, the way she'd inadvertently done on Halloween, and found that while it drew some reactions, it was inconsistent. Applied concentration and an empty mind had been the best tools she'd uncovered so far. She wondered how anyone ever learned to use their powers as a child if this was the required effort. Perhaps it was like language: it simply came more easily in earlier stages of brain development. Even Powered's at least figured out how their abilities worked, even if they couldn't willfully turn them on or off.

"Your mind is drifting."

"Sorry." Alice could never figure out how he knew when her brain started filling up with idle thoughts, but the man had a knack for it. Empty mind turned into distracted mind more than she would have expected. A couple of deep breaths dissolved the meanderings of her brain and put her concentration back on the ugly, leaning table.

The hardest part was reorienting the way she thought of her power. She'd always picture her flight as severing the connections with gravity, which had left her idly tumbling through the air when she was a Powered. No, Alice didn't ignore gravity, she repurposed it. She understood now that she oriented it in the direction of her choosing. What she could do was less flying and more incredibly-controlled falling. Alice kept that thought in mind. She wasn't trying to push the table over: she was just trying to shift the gravity slightly to the side.

Her eyes close as she imagined hundreds of hands all over the room,

each one stretching directly from the ground and grabbing an object dead center then pulling down. The hands weren't pulling hard, just firmly enough to bring down anything unbalanced. Alice put her attention on the hand gripping the table. Rather than trying to sever it or make it curl, she tried to slide it ever so slightly to the left. It moved in her mind, inch by inch, pulling the table at an increasingly acute angle. There was a soft thud as the table tumbled over, its mass too low to generate any more impressive sounds.

"Nicely done," Professor Hill complimented. Alice had to suppress the urge to squeal with joy. Every time she pulled it off she still felt a rush of surprise and giddiness. The professor moved to reset the table so she could try again.

"Wait," Alice said.

Professor Hill looked over at her. "Do you need another break?"

"No, I just want to try something."

"By all means." Professor Hill stepped back and kept his eyes on his pupil. Her brow furrowed in concentration as she stared at the now-defeated obstacle. He smiled to himself, perfectly aware of what was going through her head. She'd found a method that felt particularly effective and she wanted to test it in other applications. She was trying to recreate it, just as it had been seconds ago. If she succeeded, she'd be taking a big step forward; if she failed, she'd likely waste several days trying fruitlessly to recapture that initial sense of magic.

The table leapt from the ground and rocketed to the ceiling, smashing itself to bits against a metal support pillar.

"Very impressive."

"Not really; I was just trying to stand it up."

"Still, you got a good bit of force with that one. Control is learned through practice, and now we know you can handle heavier and more stable objects."

"You think so?"

A few splinters of particle board wafted down from the ceiling and settled on Professor Hill's shoulders. He watched them land then surveyed the other chunks of former-table that now littered the ground before him.

“I’m positive you’ll be fine.”



## 71.

Sasha and Julia were already sitting on the couch when Jill got back from class. They'd queued up some mindless fashion show that Jill had never truly understood the appeal of but had learned to fake interest in all the same. For the most part she genuinely liked her roommates and she indulged their peculiar tastes just as she was sure they indulged hers. Today she had good ground to mute the television, thankfully, as she came bearing news.

"Sooooo guess whose brother is throwing a big house party next weekend?"

Sasha paused the show, an image of a wafer-thin girl traipsing down the catwalk frozen across the screen. "Will is throwing a party? What's the theme, physics through the ages?"

"Funny. No, actually Thomas is putting it on. It's the traditional November kegger where we see which of the remaining freshmen have the balls to attend."

"Oh yeah, I remember something about that last year," Julia chimed in. "Didn't we skip it?"

"We did indeed. Evidently it was pretty decent," Sasha replied.

"Well, you won't be missing this year. Will has never been involved in planning a party before so we're going to be supportive. Plus, we want to make sure the freshmen don't make the mistake of thinking they've got more good-looking girls than our class."

"Shouldn't be too hard," Julia said. "Although they do have a girl whose ability is to appear as your heart's desire."

"Ohhhh yeah, I heard about her. Seems like cheating," Sasha pointed out.

"More cheating than a girl who eats nothing but sugar and stays thin thanks to her super-charged metabolism?"

"Touché," Sasha yielded. It would have been hard to argue the point, as she currently had a bag of marshmallows and a bowl of chips in front of her. She popped a fluffy white treat in her mouth to illustrate the point and perhaps to rub it in just a bit.

“So who all is going to be there?” Julia asked.

“According to Will so far they’ve gotten confirmation from Shane, Amber, Britney, and Gilbert. Chad is a probably since Shane is going, and I’m sure Stella will bully Camille into showing up. They only started spreading the word today, so the guest list will likely get much bigger.”

“And just how far are they planning to spread this word?” Julia asked.

“Everyone in the sophomore class is welcome to come,” Jill replied.

“Every person, or every Super?”

“Everyone.”

“If that’s the kind of party it is I’m not certain we’ll be able to make it.”

“Speak for yourself,” Sasha interrupted. She looked at Jill and gave her a smile. “Please tell Will to count me as attending.”

“Really?”

“Really?” Julia echoed.

“Really,” Sasha confirmed. She popped another marshmallow in her mouth and chewed it slowly. She still wasn’t certain how she felt about Vince or any potential of a future together, but she did know the hot poker of pain and anger that used to reside in her stomach had faded. Maybe it was his apology; maybe it was seeing things from his side. Deep down, Sasha suspected the greatest cause had simply been that hating him had been easier than missing him; however, that thought was buried too deep to be consciously considered. The hate was gone, whatever the reason, and she found the idea of seeing him at a social function somewhat appealing. Especially a social function with alcohol.

“I guess I’m going too,” Julia said, slumping slightly. She’d been trying to have her friend’s back, now she felt like she’d just come off like a snobbish bitch. She wasn’t entirely wrong.

“I’ll let him know,” Jill replied. “So what’s the plan for tonight?”

“Fashion and ice cream,” Sasha replied, restarting the show and allowing the waif of a woman to finally finish her walk.

“Awesome,” Jill lied, hoping the ice cream would at least be

enjoyable.

\* \* \*

Vince had beaten a variety of challenges in his time at Lander. He'd learned to use electricity, he'd strengthened his fighting skills, and most importantly, he'd mostly overcome his fears of losing control. Those successes made the current wall he encountered all the more frustrating. He'd tried every trick he knew, put in hours of effort, yet still he felt like he wasn't making any progress at all. It was a sentiment Roy would have understood well; however, their lack of frequent communication made such sharing unlikely. Besides, while their frustrations were the same, the causes were very different.

"Uuuugh," Vince moaned, resisting the urge to slam his head into the book. No matter how much he tried, algebra refused to make any sense to him. Part of it was his lack of traditional schooling; while his father had taught him a lot, they'd never gotten to equations this advanced. Another part was the way his brain was wired. Vince's mind simply wasn't one built for anything beyond basic math. The more effort he put into changing that fact, the more convinced he was that it was like trying to light a fire with wet stone.

"My sentiments exactly," said a voice to his side. Vince glanced over to see an unfamiliar male with the same class textbook open. They were both in the study kiosks provided by the library. There was little privacy, but since everyone was there for the same purpose, they generally worked fairly well. Many of the kiosks were available today; however, last year had taught Vince that as the semester's end drew closer they'd invariably grow more crowded every day.

"You having trouble too?"

"I'm not here because of the soothing décor," the guy chuckled. "I'm Larry, by the way."

"Vince."

"Nice to meet you, Vince, and can I say that is some awesome hair." Larry's own locks were a robin's egg blue and hung down near his eyes.

"Yours is pretty interesting as well."

"I try; Super-chic is hard to get down pat. It's so easy to go too far,

you have to walk the line between subtlety and opulence. I think you did a good job with yours.”

“Thanks.” Vince never understood why it was fashionable to try to emulate the defects that marked some people with powers, but then again, he also didn’t understand why a brown belt with black pants was considered sacrilege. Much like math, this was a subject his brain simply wasn’t built to handle.

“Look, I’m here killing time before a study group some people in my class put together starts. We could always use another person to add their brain power.”

“I appreciate it, but I’m not sure I’d be anything other than a drain. I’m pretty hopeless at this stuff.”

“All the more reason to come along. Maybe we’ll get lucky and one of the people will be a good teacher.”

Vince hesitated; he really didn’t want to intrude on someone else’s group. HCP students had to maintain a C average in every course, however, and if he didn’t find a way to get some handle on this material, he wasn’t sure that he’d pull it off in this one.

“I guess I could give it a try, if you’re sure it won’t be a bother.”

“Not at all, I’m absolutely positive you can’t be any worse at this than me.”

“I appreciate it, Larry.”

“No problem, but call me L-Ray.”

“That’s a unique name,” Vince commented.

“I’ll give the explanation later. Right now we need to head over to room C-4 if we don’t want to miss anything.”

Vince collected his notes, stuffed them in his book, and followed L-Ray in the very faint hope that his study group would offer him some semblance of comprehension.

## 72.

"I wonder what's keeping Walter," Candi said as she scanned the cafeteria. With his horn-rimmed glasses and buoyantly curly hair, her fellow freshman was generally hard to miss. He was also rather prompt in his nature, making her wonder if something had detained him after their gym session finished. She knew he'd been trying to uncover information about their mysterious upcoming midterm, and an idle hope fluttered through her that perhaps he'd had some luck.

"I'm sure he'll be along," Cameron assured her between mouthfuls of chicken. The buzz-cut sporting boy always boasted a voracious appetite after training; deep down the others often wondered how he'd managed to stay trim before the HCP had forced him into three hours of daily exercise.

"I think I saw him talking to a sophomore when we were heading to the lifts," Gale chimed in. The three of them, plus Walter, had bonded early in the year and tended to spend most of their time outside of class together. Candi initially had a bit of friction with Gale, but the two had eventually come to a point of mutual respect that was evolving into admiration.

"Really? Maybe he's making some progress on the, well, you know." The dorm cafeteria was always filled more with humans than with their kind, so Candi made a point to use vague terms whenever possible.

"Maybe," Gale replied. She turned her attention back to her salad topped only with oil and sesame seeds. Candi had to look away; she'd long ago accepted other people's dietary choices but it still turned her stomach to see such violence piled atop a plate. She focused on her own meal: two pork chops and a chicken breast. Candi got her greens when they were willingly given, not by brutally assaulting innocent plants for her own gain.

The trio ate in silence for a few minutes before a fourth figure plopped down next to them.

"Evening, all," Walter greeted.

"About time," Gale chastised. "We're almost done here."

"My sincere apologies, dear lady. I do hope you'll forgive my tardiness, I was in the depths of conversation with one of our elder classmates."

“Cut the funny talk and get to it,” Cameron urged. He was a good guy, but he could be a bit antsy.

“All right. One of the sophomores, a young man named Thomas, wanted to let me know about a party they’re throwing next Saturday,” Walter explained. “Evidently all the freshmen are invited.”

“I don’t trust it,” Gale said immediately. “I bet it’s some sort of weird hazing ritual. We show up and they make us dress like chickens or wrestle in Jell-O.”

“That actually sounds pretty fun,” Cameron pointed out.

“Speak for yourself; do you know how long Jell-O stains your skin?” All eyes turned to Candi, who began to blush immediately.

“Moving past that, though we will definitely circle back to it, my understanding is that this is something of a tradition once our class reaches its current size. It’s sort of an olive branch to let us know that we’ve lasted long enough to be part of the community.”

“I still don’t trust it,” Gale reiterated. No one was particularly surprised by her misgivings; Gale’s particular power hadn’t always led to her seeing the best in human nature. They tolerated her untrusting demeanor, if for no other reason than she had proven her ability to get past it for the sake of friendship.

“Will there be beer?” Cameron’s eyes were already shining with anticipation. If there was one thing he loved, it was beer. If there were two things he loved, it was beer and adventure. The others often joked that Cameron would have walked right through the gates of Hell if promised an open bar and a good fight.

“Multiple kegs,” Walter assured him. “It might be interesting for you three to know that I did a little extra asking around after our conversation, and this Thomas fellow is good friends with The Five.”

This drew their attention more than any other fact, with the possible exception of Cameron and his beer question. The Five were already a legend in the lower class, though none had ever dared approach them. Everyone knew the rumors: that they had been born Poweredreds but had somehow become Supers, that one was so powerful two teachers had tried to kidnap her for nefarious purposes, that The Five had been strong enough to overtake them both and rescue their friend. Many of their classmates held The Five in

contempt for their origins; however, the four students currently seated felt more curiosity toward them than anything else.

“Why would they go to a party? It’s commonly known the whole sophomore class hates them,” Gale said.

“Not the whole class,” Cameron rebutted. “I’ve seen that short girl and the goofy-looking guy hanging out with them a lot.”

“Plus it seems Thomas and his roommates have a long-standing friendship with them. They were one of the first ones to show loyalty after the big secret came out,” Walter added.

“How do you know that?” Candi asked.

Walter gave his usual noncommittal shrug. “I listen and I ask questions.” The truth was he hung out by the older students’ rooms frequently, either under the guise of being lost or having his head crammed into a book for studying. It wasn’t very dignified, so Walter tried to craft an aura of mystery to explain his extra knowledge.

“I say we go,” Cameron volunteered. “I mean, they’ve got beer.”

“No surprise there,” Candi sighed, absentmindedly brushing her blonde bangs out of her eyes. “I want to go too. It sounds like it could be pretty interesting.”

“I’m obviously in; no way I’d miss such a networking opportunity,” Walter agreed. Three sets of eyes set upon Gale, who was finishing up her salad. She chewed slowly, savoring every bit of flavor the withered plants could offer. Finally she set her fork down and looked at the others.

“I guess I could go for a little while. But the first sign of bullshit and I’m out the door.”

The other three cheered, drawing strange looks from the rest of the cafeteria. The four HCP freshmen paid the stares no attention. They were well-accustomed to being weirdoes to the bulk of the world.

### 73.

“Yo, Shades. Wait up!” Nick paused his solitary saunter toward Melbrook as a sprinting figure with tightly-braided hair caught up to him.

“Stella,” Nick greeted. “To what do I owe the pleasure of such demure company?”

“I’m supposed to spread the word about the annual freshman welcoming party,” Stella replied briskly. A normal girl would have been at least panting after such a furious dash. The time in the HCP gym had left her far from a normal girl.

“Ah yes, I remember our beer pong adventure from last year. Who is hosting?”

“We are. Well, Thomas is organizing it, but the shindig is at our place. It’s next Saturday. We’ll have kegs; but, we wanted ask you to bring liquor if possible. That shit can get expensive to provide.”

“Very true. How are you guys even getting kegs? None of you are twenty-one yet.”

Stella gave him a cunning smile. “Oh, Violet and I have our sources.”

“Slipped the guy at the beer barn an extra fifty bucks?”

“Plus some gratuitous flirting,” Stella admitted.

“Liquor shouldn’t be a problem. Hershel must have some sort of hook-up.”

“Hershel?”

Nick nodded. “He uses whiskey to turn into Roy, remember? He made that clear during last year’s fiasco. Given how much time he spends as Roy, it seems only logical he has some sort of source.”

“Oh yeah. I guess I never thought to wonder where he got his supply.”

“I’ve never asked him, but however he does it, I’m sure we can use it to get a bottle or two for the party.”

“We appreciate it,” Stella said. “So I can count you guys as coming?”



“Of course, we wouldn’t miss it,” Nick confirmed. He wasn’t actually sure if the others would want to come, but it was an opportunity to pick competitors’ minds as well as solidify relations with the few allies they still had. Tactically it was a no-brainer, plus it might alleviate some of the stress he’d noticed in the group. Vince was freaking out about class, Roy had been training relentlessly, Hershel seemed to be worried about Roy, Alice was occupied with trying to understand the new aspect of her powers as well as forgetting the incident on Halloween, and Mary was, well, she was actually doing quite fine. Aside from the awkwardness they’d been grappling with since her foray into his brain, they were actually the least tightly-wound of everyone.

“Bitchin’. I’ll tell Thomas. Spread the word around, would you?”

“Sure you want me to do that?”

“What do you mean?”

Nick slowed his walking and looked at Stella more pointedly. “I appreciate you inviting us; I even like the fact that you pretended it was no big deal. Let’s be honest, my group isn’t exactly the most beloved set of people in our class. Us being there is one thing, but do you really want us advertising the fact that we’re going to show up? I fear it might significantly drive down your attendance.”

“Spread the word around,” Stella said forcefully, her own expression not showing one bit of consternation at Nick’s words. If Nick had been one to show his feelings, he might have smiled. He liked the metaphorical balls on this girl. It made her more interesting than many of the others.

“Consider it done.”

Stella gave him a curt nod then began heading her own direction. She stopped after a few steps and called back to him.

“Hey, Nick!”

“Yes?”

“No bottom barrel shit! I don’t want to lose my eyesight over a mixed drink.”

Nick laughed quietly as he continued on his way. He might actually break out a decent bottle of something for the festivities. It seemed the least he could do to repay such stalwart support.

\* \* \*

“Hey there, pretty boy, how’s life treating you?” Angela slid next to Chad as he mechanically lifted the weights with his biceps. His gaze was distant as he focused on the exercise, but he took in her presence just as he noticed everything else.

“Good,” Chad grunted. He did a few more reps before setting the weights down. “You?”

“Supercalifragiawesome, per usual,” she replied. Her smaller hands wrapped around a pair of regular weights, the kind for people without puffed-up strength, and she began to do some shoulder lifts. “So I heard the yearly party is coming together. You going to attend?”

“Wasn’t planning on it.”

“Aw, why not?”

“Not big on parties,” Chad replied honestly. He scooped up a heavier pair of weights and began a round of triceps work. “Besides, my last outing didn’t go so well.” He’d eventually gotten control of his emotions and heard Rich’s side of the story; however, the night had still turned out to be one heck of an emotional roller coaster.

“A little birdy told me about that. I can assure you this one will be more fun. I happen to know for a fact the person hosting it is a responsible and conscientious young fellow.”

“Who is putting it on?”

“Thomas Castillo and his roommates.” Angela resisted the urge to arch her back. It would have accentuated her breasts, which she was quite proud of, but it also would have been a rookie mistake. Chad wasn’t the type to have his mind distracted by some lumps of flesh; he required a more subtle touch. Besides, it would have messed with her shoulder lifts and she was here (at least partially) to get a good workout.

“Thomas is a good man,” Chad commented.

“And I’m sure he throws a good party. Which you should go to. Next Saturday.”

Chad paused his workout and turned his attention to the female currently whittling down his resolve. “Why does it matter if I go?”

Angela stopped her own exercise as well. “Look, I didn’t want to come out and say it, but I guess I have to put my cards on the table. Thomas and his friends are nice, friendly people. They’re simply not all that powerful. Not compared to Supers like us.”

Chad nodded his agreement. Most would have taken the attitude for arrogance, but in Chad’s eyes there was nothing wrong with making valid assessments of one’s abilities. He was stronger than they, and Angela was stronger than he was when last they fought. He suspected that had changed; however, it wasn’t relevant to the discussion at hand.

“These parties are important for the freshman, but with all that alcohol and all those egos, it can get out of control. I think it would be best for everyone if someone strong enough to enforce order was in attendance.”

“I see,” Chad replied. “I still am not big on parties.”

“I know, I know. I tell you what: I’ll even give you a hand. Juniors don’t usually go, but you can bring me as your date.”

Chad raised an eyebrow.

“It’s just a pretense, moron. With both of us there, no one will dare start any stupid shit. Everybody has a good time and we can cut out early if things go smoothly.”

Chad resumed his workout and considered the proposal. He had no desire to attend such a function, and it would eat into his time for training. That being said, he did respect Thomas for his morality and his dedication. If anything happened to his home, Chad would feel guilty knowing he might have prevented it. More than that, Chad suspected Thomas was only throwing it in the first place out of a sense of duty. If he could do his part, then Chad felt he should chip in as well.

“Okay, I’ll go.”

“Great! Pick me up at six that night. We’ll grab a quick dinner then head on over.”

Chad didn’t recall agreeing to that part; however, he was slowly learning that it wasn’t worth the effort to try and argue with Shane’s sister.

## 74.

“Two more rolls ought to do it.” Stella stood up and stretched, her spine letting out a series of pops that sounded as though she’d stepped on bubble wrap. Beneath her feet was thick plastic sheeting that now covered the floor of their living room. One could scarcely even make out the carpet suffocating beneath the spill-resistant protection. That was exactly as it should be, because conversations with experienced partiers had educated them on the fact that without adequate carpet coverage, their security deposit was as good as gone.

“Thank goodness, I’m about sick of this,” Violet complained from the other side. “You’re a real peach for helping out with this crap, Camille. If I was in your place I might have made up an excuse to duck out after the first five minutes.”

“It’s not so bad,” Camille said from her spot at the opposite end of the room. She was nearly done fastening the plastic to the ground so tightly that it wouldn’t move even when tread upon by dozens of careless youths. “Sort of nice to break up the routine.”

“We appreciate it. Tell you what, on party night you have permission to cut the line to the keg as often as desired. Anyone gives you lip and I’ll handle it personally,” Stella offered.

“Thank you. I’m not sure if I’m going to come or not.”

“Not this again,” Violet spat. “We barely get to hang out anymore with us all being on separate teams. We didn’t even get to spend Halloween together. There is no way you’re ditching our freaking party.”

“Besides, I’ve heard through the grapevine that your team will be coming. Alllll of them.” Stella managed to pronounce the word “them” in a way that sounded suspiciously like “him.”

Camille reddened and turned her attention back to the plastic. “I see them all the time.”

“But you don’t see them in social situations. Ones with alcohol provided to the under-aged and small rooms for ducking away from the crowd. Who knows what kinds of team-building activities could happen in such a socially lubricated scenario?” Violet pointed out.

“I don’t think that would be very appropriate in the long term,” Camille said, hands still working even though the plastic had been attached for nearly a minute.

“It wouldn’t be appropriate in the short-term, either, but who gives a shit?” Stella asked. “This isn’t a professional team you’re spending the rest of your life with. These go until the end of the year, and that’s assuming the pros don’t pull some weird fastball and change them up to screw with us. A relationship can last much longer, and you won’t get more of an opportunity to start one than while you two are still teamed up.”

Camille considered denying her crush; however, at this point it didn’t seem like it would do any good. The girls were clearly aware of her feelings and trying to help. She was already a bad liar; there was no chance she could play things off.

“A friendship will last much longer than most relationships,” Camille said in her usual muted tones.

“Friendships can end, too. At least with a relationship you know you went for it,” Violet replied. “Plus, there are occasions when a relationship can lead back into a friendship. Thomas and I are all the closer for having dated, even after we didn’t work out.”

“That might be a bad example, I’m pretty sure he still carries the old torch for you,” Stella interjected.

“Nah, he just has a special fondness for me,” Violet said. Neither Stella nor Camille were sure if she was playing dumb or if she really didn’t notice the way Thomas’s eyes would linger on her when he thought no one else was looking. It’s possible not even Violet herself knew whether she was lying to them or herself. Regardless, nobody pressed the issue, instead turning the attention back to its original target.

“Look, Camille, we’re just trying to say that Vince has been single since the end of last semester. Now, while I don’t really get down on that whole overly-good-guy vibe, even I can see the boy is nice-looking,” Stella said. “Sooner or later some girl who does dig on that will come along, and then he’ll be off the market once more.”

“That’s okay,” Camille said reflexively. “It’s probably better that way.”

“Better for who?” Violet asked. “For him, because he’ll probably be

settling for a girl not nearly as great as you? For you, because the guy you've been blushing over since last year will be out of your reach? The only clear winner I see in that equation is whatever chick manages to snap him up."

"Vince wouldn't settle. Whoever he ends up with will be the right girl for him."

"And if the right girl is you?"

"It isn't," Camille said simply. She couldn't explain to them just how amazing he really was, how he had been acting like a Hero since he was a boy. Camille couldn't think of a way to make them understand that he was the kind of person who made the world better just by moving through it. Any girl he picked should be like him: she should be someone that lit up everything in her path with hope and light. She knew she wasn't the right girl for him, because she could never measure up.

"Big talk," Stella said. "I saw your face last year. I paid attention every time he pulled Sasha in for a tender kiss, or even just referenced having a girlfriend. I know it ripped you up inside seeing him with another girl."

"I got over it," Camille lied.

"Stella is just trying to point out that you seem to be setting yourself up for more pain if you don't at least try."

"I appreciate the advice, I really do. I just don't see it happening, and I'm happier with things the way they are."

"Have it your way," Stella said, picking up another roll of plastic wrap.

"I guess we can't force you. You are still going to come to the party. That much we can demand."

"I do miss seeing you two, even with the relationship badgering." Camille gave them a small smile to show her comment was meant in good fun.

"Well then, we'll leave it be for now. I do want you to think about how you'll react if he makes a move for you," Violet advised. "Even if you prefer that things stay platonic, not even Vince is dense enough to fail to realize what an amazing girl he has right on his team."

"I'll come up with a plan," Camille said. She would, too, however it

would be a plan that also involved unicorns from outer space flying spaceships made of candy. After all, if she was going to plan for a ridiculous scenario, she may as well make it a fun one.

## 75.

The Friday before the party, Nick discovered a note in his locker with coded instructions. It took him less time to decipher it than it did for him to put on his sneakers. Mentally he made a note to talk to Professor Pendleton about upgrading the level of cipher he was using. It wasn't that the note contained anything more than directions to meet him in a classroom within ten minutes, but it was the principle of the thing. If Nick was going to flex his brain, he may as well go for a full-on sprint rather than a light jog.

Professor Pendleton was reading at his desk when Nick arrived, some cheap paperback romance novel. One time, Nick had asked the teacher about his selections of literature. He'd been told that it was the only type of reading material supplied in prison and that once one developed a taste for it, the books were actually quite enjoyable.

"Rodrigo sweeping the widow off her feet?" Nick asked as he took a load off his own and slunk into a chair.

"He was, but now the local bank owner has come between them in an effort to win her for himself," Professor Pendleton replied, carefully setting in a bookmark before closing his novel. "So, you ready for your midterms?"

"If my assessment of my own understanding is accurate, I should breeze through with at least a B in everything."

"You know if you applied yourself you could be valedictorian."

"And if Einstein had put his smarts toward women instead of physics he could have been knee-deep in trim. That's not the way his priorities lined up, now is it?" Nick wore his usual cocky grin, however it was slightly subdued in these sessions. He kept in character – it was something he prided himself on - but with Professor Pendleton, he showed occasional bits of respect.

"Cute. That one take you long to think up?"

"Meh, about five minutes. Had it in the barrel for over a month, though. Thanks for the set-up."

"My pleasure," Professor Pendleton said. "And since you're doing so well on your academics, I think you can handle a little something extra. I've called you in to talk about your midterm for my class." While aboveground



classes only lasted single semesters, the HCP ones ran the duration of a school year. This meant the winter break was only halfway through the term for most of them.

“I thought we weren’t getting anything from the HCP?”

“Most students aren’t. Then again, most students aren’t half-assing their way through the public portion of my class. This is especially pertinent when my class is the only one in which they stand a reasonable chance of advancing.” Professor Pendleton stood from his desk and opened one of the drawers on the side.

“Ah, so this is my price for our arrangement.”

“I’d prefer to think of it as extra credit to keep you even with the class.” He withdrew five pieces of stiff paper from the desk, each one a blank white square from Nick’s vantage point. Professor Pendleton crossed the distance between them and extended the papers. “Pick a card, any card.”

Nick began to reach out, nearly touching one before the professor slapped his hand away.

“Sunglasses off, if you don’t mind.”

“Got a problem with a little luck on my side?”

“I prefer to leave this up to genuine chance. No weighting the odds.” Professor Pendleton smiled placidly, his face indicating that this was in no way optional.

Nick sighed dramatically as he removed his shades. Looking his teacher in the eye, he reached out and grabbed one of the papers at random. A quick flip to the other side revealed only two words were printed on it: ‘Blake Hill.’

“Am I supposed to kill him?”

“Tempting, but no,” Professor Pendleton replied. He took the paper back from Nick and slipped it into the stack. After a brief walk over to the desk he deposited them in the drawer from whence they came. “It looks like learning about Professor Hill is your assignment.”

“What are you looking for: favorite color, if he cheats on his wife, where he buys his pants?”

“No, I want to really test your information gathering skills,” Professor

Pendleton replied. "I want you to uncover the secret he keeps the closest to his heart. You're going to find out his Hero code name."

Nick let out a low whistle. "That's not a bad one. I don't have much to go on. He hasn't even used his power in class yet; actually, no one besides Professor Stone and Professor Fletcher has."

"Advanced mind is one of the more common abilities, so she has little risk in revealing what she can do. As for Professor Fletcher, well, I'm sure you can reach the obvious conclusion there. The rest of them guard the exact nature of their abilities to avoid someone doing exactly what I'm instructing you to do."

"So is this above-board?"

"As above-board as anything in the Subtlety field ever is," Professor Pendleton replied. "Information is our bread and butter; it's what makes us truly useful. Sometimes doing a little research on a friend in the present is good preparation for a worst-case scenario in the future."

"People call me a cynical bastard when I say things like that," Nick said, a splash of bitterness discernible in his voice.

"Good for them. Better that only a few of us have to think this way," Professor Pendleton slid into his chair and picked up the book once more. "You have until the end of January. Any questions?"

"If it's a midterm why is the due date next semester?"

"Because it's an off-the-books midterm, so I can set the deadline whenever I please. I thought giving you more time was a kind gesture."

"Just checking," Nick replied. He stood from his own chair and placed the sunglasses back on his face. "So all you need is the codename he used when he was a Hero?"

"You got it. This is pass or fail, all or nothing."

"Yeah yeah yeah. I'll have it before Christmas."

"Good luck with that."

"That's the one thing I know I'll have," Nick shot back with an exaggerated wink. Professor Pendleton couldn't see his eye close, of course, but the muscle movements of his eyebrow left no doubt as to what he'd done. With that, Nick was gone and his tutor was left alone, save only for the

company of a good book.

Before continuing to read, Professor Pendleton reached into the drawer and took out the pieces of paper again. This wasn't his classroom, and it wouldn't do to have anyone find five identical cards, all with Professor Hill's name written on them. For a moment Sean had worried Nick would ask to see the others, but it seemed denying him his luck ability had convinced him that the papers were different. He stuffed the pages in his pocket then turned his attention back to Rodrigo, who was languishing over the seemingly insurmountable obstacle barring him from his love.

## 76.

It had taken Candi more tries than she cared to admit to select her outfit for the party. She'd eventually settled on a forest green top paired with a push-up bra to try and fill it out properly. Gale hadn't bothered with more than a glance in the closet, of course; she could be as pretty as she needed to be at a moment's notice. Candi always hated Gale a little bit for that, but she supposed if the roles were reversed, she probably would have done the same. When Walter picked them up, he having been selected as the designated driver, it was no surprise that he was wearing a recently-pressed polo while Cameron sported his standard t-shirt and sneakers. Candi swore that boy would show up to his own wedding underdressed, assuming he ever settled into a relationship in the first place.

They arrived at the house in question about a half hour after it would have been fashionably late. There were plenty of excuses for why, but the truth of it was that they wanted a thick crowd so they could blend in if desired. The party was a scary prospect for most of them, and having a little cover made it easier to cope with. They needn't have worried: there was certainly no shortage of bodies crammed into the building.

"Glad you could make it," Thomas said, standing sentry at the door. "Who is your DD?"

Walter raised his hand sheepishly and Thomas slashed an X mark across the back of it before Walter could react.

"I wasn't aware this was a bar," Walter mumbled as he stared at his hand.

"Nothing personal, but I don't know how responsible you typically are. As long as that mark is on, no one will give you any alcohol, but no one will give you grief for not drinking either. The ink was specially created by one of my roommates, Will, so you can try and scrub if you want but it won't come off for twelve hours. Now, aside from my own enforcement of the designated driver policy, there aren't many house rules. This is an HCP party, so feel free to use your powers. It's a safe environment. That said, please refrain from doing any damage to the house. We do have to live here after this is over."

"Anything else?" Candi asked.

“Kegs are in the garage, liquor is in the kitchen, and there are some snack foods in the dining room. Make yourselves at home and have fun.”

Cameron darted forward in a beeline; not one of his friends had to wonder which location he was going toward. The others ambled in gradually, absorbing the scene before them as they tried to get into a party mood. There were more of their classmates than they’d expected, but fewer than they might have hoped for. Sophomores made up the bulk of the bustling bodies, and though their gazes lingered on the unfamiliar faces, the freshmen didn’t sense any hostility from the older students. After a few minutes of acclimation, they made their way to the kitchen to try a few mixed drinks.

\* \* \*

“Younger girls, Vince. Younger girls are heaven’s gift to strapping lads like us: still old enough to be legal, but inexperienced enough to perceive our advanced age as maturity. Herding them all together like this and adding alcohol, why, it’s practically unfair.” Nick took a swig of his cocktail to punctuate the point.

“I still can’t believe you talked me into coming out here,” Vince fussed. “I should be studying.”

“Algebra can wait, my dear boy; you’ll be just as clueless tomorrow as you were today.”

“That’s sort of the problem,” Vince replied. It was a testament to how stressed out school had made him that a red plastic cup filled with beer was clutched in his hand. He’d even managed to drink half of it over the course of the last hour. Roy and the girls were engaged in a flip-cup tournament that was in its final matches, so he and Nick had wandered around to do more meet-and-greets. They’d both been in the tournament as well; however, their team lost in the first round thanks to Vince’s unsteady hands and Nick’s intentional lack of coordination.

“Look, you’re making progress thanks to that study group of yours. Try and relax a little bit. The human mind can only stay cranked up to the max for so long before something fries itself. You need to take breaks; any book on how to cram will tell you the same thing,” Nick assured him. It was actually a little off-putting to see Vince’s nerves frayed. The guy was generally so unflappable that Nick had been starting to wonder if he even could get riled up outside of combat.

“I know, I know,” Vince muttered, taking another sip of his beer. “I

just have to do well. If I want to stay in, I mean.”

“It’ll be okay. Just take tonight off and I promise you’ll find a way. The test is still a few weeks off, and if you don’t feel secure by the time it rolls around, I’ll personally oversee your tutoring.”

“Thanks. You’re a good friend, Nick.”

“I do what I can.”

“Excuse me,” said a freshman girl with her blonde hair cut short and spiky. “Could you please pass me some cups?” Another girl stood behind her wearing clothes that looked like they’d been on the floor for a week, and behind her was a boy in glasses trying very hard to look like he wasn’t trying very hard.

“No problem,” Nick said with trademark smirk. He nimbly plucked three cups from the top of the stack and tossed one to each student. “You all enjoying the party?”

“Well, we just got here, but so far it seems fun,” said the blonde.

“It certainly is. I’m Nick, by the way, and the gentleman nursing his beer like Florence Nightingale is Vince.”

“Nice to meet you. I’m Candi, these two are Gale and Walter.”

“A pleasure to make your acquaintance. Vince and I will get out of your way so you can cobble together some cocktails, but if you should need anything, please don’t hesitate to ask.” Nick squeezed his way out of the kitchen, followed by Vince who gave them a much more genuine smile coupled with a thumbs up.

“They seemed nice,” Vince commented as the duo made their way to the garage. The tournament was bound to be nearing completion and both required a refill.

“They did, and we seemed aloof yet interesting. I’m telling you, younger girls. That’s where it’s at, my protégé.”

“How am I the protégé? I’ve actually had a girlfriend in college,” Vince pointed out.

“I dated around,” Nick replied. He’d ended things with Bubbles early last summer, when he had yet to decide whether returning to Lander was in his best interests. “Now, let’s go see what other promising prospects have

wandered into our den of intoxication.”

“You get wordy when you drink.” Vince finished off the remainder of his beer as they headed into the garage. He had to admit, he did feel a little less stressed about the test. Maybe he’d have one or two more.

Sasha greeted Thomas with a familiar nod as she and Julia walked in the door. Neither of them needed a designated driver: this Julia was a duplicate that the original had dropped off and Lander was scarcely more than a few seconds' jog away for Sasha. Besides, she wasn't here to get hammered beyond coherency. Sasha was a woman with a mission; she merely wasn't sure what that mission was yet. She'd selected an outfit of skin-tight jeans and a low-cut top paired with a push-up bra. A rare touch of make-up and some attention to her hair left no doubt that Sasha was looking to draw attention tonight. Whose attention wasn't the least bit in doubt, either: this sumptuous little ensemble had been crafted for one silver-haired individual. Whether it was meant to win him back, make him miss her, or simply prove that she still drew his attention, Sasha still couldn't figure out. Perhaps it was some strange combination of all of them. Perhaps it was none of them. She knew she wanted him looking at her tonight, that thought sat in her mind with certainty.

A cursory glance of the living room was all it took to assess her competition. Jill, Selena, and Violet were chatting away near the stereo, so Will and Alex were presumably in attendance. None of the girls were an issue: Selena was gorgeous but taken, Thomas clearly still had feelings for Violet, and Jill was Will's sister, so Vince would consider both off limits. Angela was leaning against a wall, making small talk with Chad. The girl was beautiful in a fearsome sort of way; it was the type of beauty Vince could actually appreciate. Fortunately, Angela had her predatory eyes clearly set on the specimen in front of her, so she posed little threat. Aside from a few freshmen scattered about in the kitchen and some of the men from her class trying to look less awkward than they felt, that seemed to be the entirety in attendance. A loud roar of cheers from the garage informed Sasha of her mistake and she re-oriented her direction almost immediately.

"Don't you want a drink?" Julia asked, motioning to the kitchen.

"I'm more in the mood for beer." If the crowd was in the garage then the kegs almost certainly were as well.

"Bleh." Julia stuck out her tongue. "I'm sick of beer. I want something sweet."

"Lucky for you we took such delicate sensibilities into account," Violet said. She'd detached from her group of girls to greet the new arrivals.



Neither Sasha nor Julia had noticed her cross the room, but given the general levels of background noise and movement, it was hardly a failing on their part.

“We made pink-panty-dropper punch,” Violet explained.

“Sounds dangerous.” Her words might have been cautious but Julia’s smile was eager.

“It’s essentially a bunch of pink lemonade and everclear thrown in a cooler, with a bit of fruit and additives for flavoring. We set it up near the beer.”

“You’ve sold me: to the garage!” Julia thrust a finger in the air and began a dramatic march forward.

“She’s in a mood tonight.”

“It’s been a long week; I think we’re both overdue for a little fun.”

Violet gave Sasha an up and down assessment. “Looks like someone is angling for more fun than a little.”

“Girl’s got the right to turn some heads.”

“Amen to that. Come on, let’s follow your roommate. I need a new beer, plus they’ll be playing quarters pretty soon.”

\* \* \*

“Wow, this stuff is way better than beer,” Vince commented as he sipped from Alice’s cup. Her team had lost the flip-cup tournament, and as such she was beer-bloated enough to switch to the punch for a while. The line for it was shorter than the line for the beer as well, which had prompted Vince’s curiosity. “I’m going to grab a cup of this instead.” He headed over to the cooler to wait behind Amber and Britney, who were already filling their own cups with the concoction.

“I wonder if we should warn him about this stuff being stronger than it tastes,” Alice said as her friend stood cheerfully in line.

“Nah, I’m sure he’ll be fine. Vince is a smart guy,” Nick replied. He took a draw from his own drink, partially out of thirst and partially to conceal the smile that was tugging at his lips. A year ago it might have worked, but Alice was a wiser woman these days.

“You’re hoping he accidentally gets smashed, aren’t you?”

“Obliterated.”

“That’s just mean.”

Nick shook his head. “He’s been worrying himself sick for weeks now over his math class. Add that to the normal amount of ‘weight of the world’ bull that guy carries around and I’m scared he’ll give himself an ulcer before Christmas.”

“And alcohol is the answer?”

“Fun is the answer. Doing things you wouldn’t normally do, making a few mistakes.” Nick noticed Sasha slink into the garage, sheer sex bundled into tight jeans and topped with pink-streaked hair. “Maybe repeating a few mistakes that are particularly fun.”

“You’re awful,” Alice sighed. She made no motion to go warn Vince. He’d probably figure it out after the first cup, and if he didn’t then maybe that was okay, too. Things had been tightly wound lately; a little recklessness was practically demanded.

“Hey, lovebirds, if you can tear yourselves apart, Camille and I need some opponents,” Stella called, holding up a pair of darts. Camille looked properly shamed by such an inappropriate greeting but Stella wore a cocksure grin that said she knew what she’d said and was confident she’d struck close to the truth.

“Lovebirds, huh? I think she’s trying to rattle us,” Nick said.

“She’ll need to do better than that,” Alice replied honestly. She wasn’t sure if she trusted Nick again, not yet, but after Halloween, she was done pretending she didn’t like being around him. He was the one she’d cried against for hours, and all he’d done in response was hold her close. He knew words would be wasted; he got that there was no simple fix for what was wrong. Nick understood her, at least a little bit, and that connection was something that made her feel better when he was around. It was enough, at least for right now.

“Let’s go kick some steel-shifting ass,” Alice quipped as the duo set off to do battle on the ground of thrown projectiles.

## 78.

Roy was rarely impressed by anything that didn't involve D-cups and a size zero waist, but as he watched the freshman pour yet another cup of beer down his throat, he had to admit it was something worth watching. The kid had introduced himself as Cameron then put a hurting on the kegs that would have left a rock star envious. The boy was basically filling his lean frame with hops-brewed alcohol as fast as he could work his way through the line. Most of the freshmen in this situation were more timid or bashful about their activities. Not this kid. Roy admired that sort of bravado.

"What's that make, fifteen?"

"Probably," Cameron said with a shrug. "I'm not great at counting."

"Most people at that point wouldn't be great at standing."

"I've got a high tolerance."

"So I can see. I heard you say you're Cameron, right? I'm Roy Daniels." He held out his hand, which the younger boy accepted and immediately shook. His grip was strong, beyond what a human would have been able to casually manage, but not overly impressive by Super standards.

"I know who you are, but it's nice to meet you officially."

"My legendary drinking and fighting prowess precedes me, huh?"

"Nah, everyone in my class just knows about the Powered's who got into the HCP." If Cameron was at all aware of the subtle tension that bloomed from the people standing around him, he didn't show it. In fact, he did nothing more than down another half of a beer in a single swift sip.

Roy stared at the smaller boy with forced calm. Given his size and seeming strength, there were limited options for why he'd make a comment like that. Either he was an idiot, he was much more powerful than he seemed, or he simply was too thick to realize it might be an offensive thing to say. Before Lander, Roy would have dismissed the last one immediately, but time with Vince and Chad had shown him that some perfectly competent people could have social blind spots the size of elephants. He decided to test the waters before selecting a reaction.

"We were Powered's. We're Supers now."

“Oh, my bad. The grapevine sucks at details.” He took another swig of beer and stared at Roy quizzically. It looked like it was the socially ignorant option after all. Roy was glad he’d resisted the urge to hurl the kid through the wall. Thomas probably would have never forgiven him for the repair bills.

“I think one of the beer pong tables is open. Let’s fill a pitcher and see what you’ve got,” Roy said with a charming smile.

“Cool.” Cameron didn’t worry about much as long as there was beer. For his part, Roy was confident he could keep the tone of the match more fun than the one Hershel and Nick had started last year. Not to mention this kid had obviously come here with friends, some of whom were female. Freshman girls were easy-pickings, and establishing a bond with their buddy would be a faster way in than doing a cold approach. Despite his thick muscles and fist-first attitude, Roy Daniels could employ a bit of tact and strategy when it came to the fairer sex.

\* \* \*

Candi stood out in the yard and tried to will away her tension. She wasn’t like Cameron with his unflappable nature, or Gale with her power to see through people, or even Walter and his clumsy schemes to ingratiate himself to others. Candi was a girl who was comfortable in solitude, who liked her own company in a way that most people would spend lifetimes trying to emulate. However, enjoying alone time and being immune to needing companionship were different things.

College, and the HCP especially, had shown her the importance of having friends. That was why she was here tonight. Her discomfort in unfamiliar situations was why she currently stood on the dilapidated grass that passed for a backyard.

The new owners were working to undo the neglect of countless tenants before them, Candi could have seen that even without her abilities. There were fresh sprouts popping out of the ground, eagerly bursting forth from soil that was finally being watered with regularity. She could feel their joy, their drive to grow big and strong. Plants were so positive most of the time; it was why humans found nature so soothing. Candi liked to believe that even though everyone couldn’t hear the flora the way she could, they could still sense its goodness in some way.

“Having fun?”

Candi nearly leapt out of her sandals. She’d been so focused on the

sounds of the plants around her that she'd missed the more obvious noise of a door opening behind her. Once her heartbeat slowed to a dull hammering, she turned around to see the person who'd accidentally snuck up on her. He was a sophomore, short in stature with a pair of glasses resting beneath light curly hair.

"I am, I just needed some air," Candi said lamely.

"I completely understand. These things can be a bit over-whelming." He sat down on a stone bench that rested near the door. Despite the fact that he carried a plastic cup, he didn't seem to be drawing from it with the same enthusiasm as the other party-goers.

"Tell me about it. I like meeting new people and all, I guess I just wish it wasn't all so..."

"Loud?"

"Exactly. Loud." Candi wandered over and sat down in a lawn chair a few feet away from the bench. "I like quiet conversation better. When does that become the default way to make new friends?"

"Based on my observations, long after you've already made the important ones."

"I was afraid of that." Candi chuckled lightly. "I'm Candi."

"Will. I'm one of the actual tenants here."

"That explains why you're in attendance."

"Sadly I suspect I'd be here even if it weren't the case. I've grown some friendships that encourage me to step outside my comfort zone with more frequency than I would generally prefer." Will's eyes were skyward, picking out the few constellations visible despite the cloudy night. "Such is the trade-off of friendship: you are forced into situations you're not secure in, but in return you have people who assure you security in any situation. Quite a fascinating system when you think it over."

"Yeah, it is."

Will rose quietly from his seat. "On that note, I should go check on my guests. Perhaps you should see what your friends are up to as well."

"Good idea." Candi got up and followed the shorter boy back into the ruckus-filled fray that was colloquially known as a party.



## 79.

When Sasha found Vince he was already on the losing end of a game of quarters with Gilbert. He didn't seem too down about it, smiling and accepting his drinks with a curiously cheerful demeanor. It didn't take a detective to piece things together, especially when he looked up and noticed her arrival.

"Sasha!" He leapt up from his metal folding chair and enveloped her in a wide-armed hug. She stiffened with surprise initially, but then relaxed as familiarity and nostalgia swept through her heart. She'd missed his hugs, and even drunken, they still held the same reassuring quality. It was like he was trying to squeeze all the sentiments he was too awkward to articulate into a single loving gesture. Sasha let the embrace go for just a few instants longer than she might have if he were sober - they weren't on that good of terms yet - then carefully disengaged herself and flashed him a warm smile.

"I see someone is enjoying himself."

"Yeah, sorry about that," Nick interjected, walking over from his vantage point of observing a beer pong game. "Alice and I left him unattended to play some darts earlier in the evening, and before you know it he'd gone through two cups of the punch."

"Is it that strong?"

"It ain't jet fuel but I wouldn't feed it to an infant, either. It's decent, but you've got to remember who we're talking about here."

"Right." Sasha had been with Vince the entirety of last year and in that time she could only remember him occasionally taking sips of other people's drinks, never indulging in one of his own. That meant despite his well-trained physique he had virtually no tolerance for alcohol. "What actually got him drinking anyway?"

"I found something that tastes good," Vince replied, punctuating his sentence with a sloppy gulp of pink liquid.

"That, and he has been worrying his ass off about one of his tests. He's scared he won't do well enough to stay in the program."

"Killjoy." Vince stuck his tongue out at Nick.

Sasha chuckled, not just at the idiocy of her former boyfriend but at the idea of him worrying about a test. She'd seen Vince shrug off nearly everything that came his way with that same unwavering determination. He would get through any challenge because he had to: that was just his way. To hear that a regular class had gotten under his skin was frankly, well, adorable. It was nice to see even the seemingly unstoppable had fears.

"We should probably slow him down," Sasha recommended.

"Tried that; he just poaches more drinks when my back is turned."

"You're not all that smart, are you?" Sasha turned to Vince and gently took his cup. "Hey, Vince, you want a drink that tastes really good?"

"Better than the punch?" Even intoxicated his tone was skeptical.

"So good you'll swear there's no alcohol in it at all. It's as smooth and refreshing as water, I promise."

"Wow. Okay." Vince yielded his cup and Sasha flashed Nick a "told you so" look before heading toward the kitchen. Drunk or not, Vince was incredibly trusting and kind of an idiot. It made him into the sort of person who could maintain such staunch ideals in the face of a world that didn't share them, and it also made him incredibly easy to manage if one was willing to put in a little effort.

Back in the garage, Vince looked at Nick and put a hand on his friend's shoulder. "She looked really pretty."

Nick laughed freely, not bothering to disguise his mirth. "Oh man, I am going to get you drunk more often."

"Sounds good!" Vince meandered off, not waiting for a reply. Nick turned to check on the status of the beer pong game and when he looked back, Vince had procured yet another cup of the colorful punch. It was actually impressive how easily he produced them, like some bizarre booze magic trick. Nick considered snatching away the new acquisition, then shrugged it off. Sasha seemed to want to take care of him, so he'd leave it to her. Besides, if ever there was a place for Vince to cut loose a little, it was in a room full of Supers who could handle any problems he might create.

\* \* \*

Mary and Camille sat on a dilapidated couch that had been set alongside threadbare chairs in the hopes of creating a makeshift lounge area.



It provided an excellent view of the garage as well as a vantage point to see out the garage door, allowing one to observe various comings and goings as they occurred. Neither of the small-framed girls sipped on anything stronger than soda, but after watching the way Vince and Sasha had embraced, Camille was beginning to find herself sorely tempted.

“I wouldn’t recommend it,” Mary said, loud enough to be heard yet soft enough not to be overheard.

“Sorry?” Neither girl had said much beyond the usual friendly chit-chat upon taking a seat. They were both more comfortable as silent observers than as active participants, at least when it came to situations like these.

“I wouldn’t recommend getting a drink. I don’t think it will help the situation.”

“Oh, you heard that?”

“I did, and even if I didn’t I could have guessed it. You sort of wear your feelings on your face,” Mary explained.

“I know.” Lying to a telepath was a waste of both of their time. She tried anyway. “It doesn’t bother me that much.”

“Or at least you feel like it shouldn’t. Like you don’t have the right to be hurt by it. He isn’t anything more than your friend, after all.”

Camille nodded.

“Did you know Roy and Hershel share memories?” Mary didn’t look at Camille as she spoke; both girls kept their eyes trained on the active people bustling through the party.

“They do?”

“Thoughts, emotions, memories, everything one experiences the other can recall. It’s the closest thing to communication they have,” Mary explained. “That means even though Hershel has never cheated on me, he regularly wakes up with crisp, genuine memories of sleeping with other women. My boyfriend is a virgin, but he has literally hundreds of woman as a standard of comparison.”

“Hundreds?”

“Roy can be charming when he wants to be,” Mary said. “The point is, Hershel can’t help that any more than I can help hearing what people think.

It's a part of his ability and the only way to stop it would be to deny an entire part of who he is. That's something I don't have the right to be mad about, if only because I knew it going in."

"So it doesn't bother you?" Camille looked at her team captain with a new measure of awe.

"Of course it bothers me. It bothers me all the damn time."

"That seems awful."

"It is, but that's not why I brought it up. See, it's an example of something that can't be helped. If I want to be with Hershel then I can't really complain about it. You, on the other hand, have feelings for a single man who is well within your reach. You have every right to be bothered when he squeezes his ex-girlfriend like she's going to spurt candy. You don't have to feel bad about feeling bad. And you don't have to do nothing about it either."

"Yes, I do." Camille could have tried harder to keep the sadness off her face, but she couldn't really see the point.

"You can take care of him. Friends do that, and the way he's plowing through the punch, he'll probably need it."

"Sasha has that in hand."

"Sasha's first recourse was trickery. That's not the only way to guide Vince to a conclusion. Besides, can she heal the damage his liver is taking?"

"Probably not," Camille ceded.

"So go be his friend. Keep him safe, whatever that entails."

Camille looked at Mary for a long minute, then set down her water and got up from the couch. She couldn't get too close to him; she couldn't risk losing the relationship they shared. She could, as a friend, still protect him. That was why she'd worked this hard, why she'd come this far. She could take care of him, no matter who else was around. That much was within Camille Belden's power.

## 80.

Thomas eventually left his post at the door to join the revelry, but only once he was sure the bulk of the guests had arrived. It seemed like things were going well - the general vibe was certainly more relaxed than at last year's festivities. The few freshmen who'd bothered to attend looked like they were enjoying themselves. A couple milled about in the living room making conversation, some participated in the drinking games set up in the garage, and one looked to be racing Roy to the bottom of the keg. Angela and Chad greeted him with their usual nods, and Thomas thought he saw a smattering of approval in the smile Angela flashed him. He could see why: things were going along as well as could be expected.

Thomas tried to take a detour to the bathroom, only to walk in on a couple getting exceptionally familiar on the counter of the sink. He closed the door before investigating identities: there were some things he was probably better off being ignorant of. It wasn't like he blamed the duo - there were scarce private places to be found and with this much social lubricant, such instances were bound to occur.

The thought that followed on that one's heels, not that Thomas would accept that there was any connection between the two, was that he should check on his housemates and make sure they were all doing okay. Thomas turned his attention in search of Violet and the others, winding his way back through the rooms. He snatched up a few abandoned cups as he went: just because it was a party didn't mean he couldn't get a head start on the eventual clean-up.

\* \* \*

The inevitable had happened, and thankfully it had happened in a toilet rather than on anyone's shoes. Despite Sasha's secret water and Camille's watchful eye, Vince's stomach had turned after only a few drinks more. Camille had offered her services in aid to Sasha and the two had gotten him upstairs where he proceeded to make a valiant offering to the porcelain god. The two women stood outside during the assault, neither one particularly wanting to get the visual on such an event.

"You can probably head back down if you want," Sasha said, partly just to verbally cover the series of sickening sounds coming from the open doorway. "I'll just clean him up, throw some water in him, and put him to bed

in Will's room."

"That's not a good idea until we're sure he's done vomiting. If he gets on his back and throws up in his mouth he can choke to death."

"First off, yuck. Second, what are the odds of that?"

"More than you'd think. I took some emergency care classes at the local hospital when I was younger. Apparently there are multiple cases of people dying that way every year," Camille explained.

"Really? I guess I'll prop him up, then." Sasha was interrupted by a fresh wave of audio from the restroom. "That might be a while from now. So, why did you take emergency classes? Can't you fix everything with a touch?"

"Not everything. Illness is really hit or miss for me, depending on what kind it is. There are very few healers who can deal with all forms of infection and sickness, so learning some general treatment practices was a good idea. Plus, it never hurts to expand your knowledge."

"I bet it also looked good on your application to Lander." Sasha flashed her classmate a conspiring grin. Camille reciprocated as best she could. The noise from the bathroom began to dull, and Camille risked a quick peek to ensure his head was still above the rim.

"How is he?"

"Looks stable for the moment. Let's give him a bit."

"Good call," Sasha agreed.

The two stood in silence, save only for when Camille ventured into the bathroom to give the toilet a quick flush. Vince stirred briefly, mumbled a pair of words and then set his head back onto the seat. The girls had wiped it liberally with some cleaning pads before letting him settle down, but Camille still couldn't help wondering how sanitary a practice this really was.

"Why don't you use some of your healing ability to make him better?" Sasha asked as Camille emerged from her unpleasant adventure.

"I did that on the way up the stairs. I healed his liver, but the alcohol is still in his system. The symptoms won't go away until it runs its course."

"I see. So all I can do is wait."

"Seems like it's our only option."

“Gotcha. Well, while we’re standing around, I was wondering something. How long have you had feelings for my ex-boyfriend?”

Camille reddened immediately but she didn’t look at the ground. Instead she met Sasha’s stare dead on, even shifting her feet a bit to close the height gap between the two. “What do you mean?”

“It’s okay, you don’t need to deny it. I’ve given you multiple chances to leave Pukey yet you stay; you even went in to flush despite his current combustive nature. When I think about the way you’re always gazing up at him, it all falls into place.”

“I wasn’t denying it. I was literally asking for clarification on what you meant. If you mean to ask how long I’ve admired him, the answer is a very long time. How long have I been attracted to him is obviously since I saw him. If you want to know how long I’ve cared deeply for him... well, now that I think about it, that’s really none of your business anyway.” Camille’s insides were churning with a fervor only Vince’s could currently equal, but she stood her ground and refused to look away.

“Look at you, getting all puffed up for a change.” Sasha attempted a friendly smile, but succeeded only in resembling a tiger showing its teeth to a house cat. “There’s no need to get upset. He’s my ex after all. I was just making conversation.”

“Then I apologize for misunderstanding your meaning,” Camille replied, lowering her stance but keeping her eyes locked with Sasha’s. The two might have stayed like that all night, if not for the sounds of a silver-haired young man pulling himself up from the toilet and lumbering to the doorway.

“Anybody have any mouthwash? There’s a flavor on my tongue that would curdle milk.” He gave a weak smile to his two caretakers, who immediately let the tense mood between them dissolve.

“I’ll put a cup for you by the bed. I’ll also leave a bottle of water and a trash can, just in case,” Camille volunteered. She nearly dashed from the room while Sasha began helping Vince over to the bed. Her heart was thundering, partially because of her confrontation with Sasha, but more from fear that Vince might have overheard their discussion. They’d been speaking low; however, that didn’t mean he hadn’t at least gotten snippets.

By the time Camille had found a free trash can and a big enough bottle of water, she’d managed to calm her nerves a bit. She reminded herself that

even if Vince had gotten pieces of the conversation, there was virtually no way he'd recollect them in the morning. He was well beyond out of it; after all, when she'd gone in to flush he'd mumbled something that sounded like "stop, thief." That made no sense at all. At least, that's what she kept telling herself over and over as she climbed the stairs back to the room where the man she loved was waiting.

## 81.

Angela was impressed: the celebration had lasted most of the evening before any semblance of a fight had broken out. She'd had to put down two half-hearted scraps before the freshmen had even arrived at her party. It was a little surprising that Thomas had managed to keep the peace for so long, though who had broken it was somewhat less shocking.

"Should we intervene?" Chad was standing next to her, looking delicious as always. For a guy who didn't seem to care much about his looks, Angela couldn't help noticing that his hair was always nicely styled and his complexion impeccable. Given his power, these things probably took almost negligible effort to maintain, but it was still effort he exerted. Chad could put on the dedicated tough act all day long; Angela knew there was a bit of vanity and ego under the calm warrior's surface.

"I don't see any reason to; so far it seems to be a friendly match. Better they release their aggression harmlessly than let it loose in more destructive ways."

Across the yard stood Roy and the freshman boy, Cameron or some such, both doing a preliminary stretch or two as the crowd of intoxicated students mingled about. A few other freshmen were speckled through the growing audience, three of them with looks of evident concern. Cameron himself seemed quite nonchalant, perhaps the gallons of beer he'd put away were the cause of such chillness.

The cluster parted as Thomas made his way outside. He looked at the two men preparing to do battle and let out a long, exasperated sigh before speaking.

"Who insulted whom?"

"Neither," Roy said with an oversized grin. He looked like a kid waiting in line for a new roller coaster than he'd yet to scream his way through. "We were just drinking and talking, and Cameron mentioned his abilities were physically-based as well. Couple of beers later we decided to have ourselves a match."

"A couple of beers' is something of an understatement," Alice chipped in from the sidelines. Even half-buzzed and in the cool wind of the California air, she still looked dazzling. Angela was very thankful the girl was

inept in choosing men and procuring them, otherwise she might have had some real competition for her current conquest.

“We had enough,” Roy replied. “Now hold my hat.” He tossed the ever-present grey cowboy hat to Angela, which she caught with some distaste.

“What on earth makes you think a fight in my backyard is a good idea?” Thomas inquired.

“You’ve got high fences. Besides, we’re just horsing around. No mega-strength punches or tossing each other half a mile away. Just the first to three pins wins.”

“I’ll be quick,” Cameron promised from a few feet away. He’d finished his own stretches and was hopping impatiently in place.

“This seems like an awful idea,” Thomas reiterated.

Angela waltzed forward slowly, letting the crowd register her presence and slide away appropriately. She’d learned long ago how to project an aura of power and intimidation. It didn’t come from being aggressive or showing your strength; if anything it was the opposite. People saw true power when they witnessed someone who could move with a blissful peace, no matter what was happening around them. That confidence only came from being so strong that you had nothing that required your worry. Anyone could learn to project that image, but if you actually had the power to back it, then it was dozens of times more effective. And Angela definitely had the power.

“Let them be,” she said as she slid up to Thomas’s side. “You can’t control morons, you can only point them in a useful direction. If things get out of hand, Chad and I will put a swift stop to it.” Her words were for Thomas, but both of the would-be fighters got a dose of her eyes. She made sure each understood that the consequences of her stepping in would be exceptionally unpleasant. They seemed to absorb as much of her message as their booze-addled brains were capable of. With that settled, Angela put her hand on Thomas’s shoulder and led the party host back a few steps. There was immediate bickering directly behind her; a cursory glance revealed it to be the freshmen she assumed were Cameron’s friends. She started to listen to their conversation, but her attention was drawn to the action as it started.

Cameron kicked things off with a headlong charge right at Roy’s torso. If the older boy was surprised, it was only because he wasn’t accustomed to someone pulling his own signature move on him. Unluckily for Cameron, all of Roy’s experience with this technique had given him first-



hand experience on how it could be countered. Roy struck with a quick elbow to the shoulder blade, obliterating Cameron's balance and leaving him wide open for the knee that was driven into his hip. If it had been against a regular opponent, such a strike would only have further skewed his balance, but from someone like Roy, the blow flipped him several feet into the air. He landed chest-first in the grass with a soft thud. Roy moved to capitalize, but the freshman was surprisingly quick to recover. A single punch against the ground launched him back to his feet.

The two combatants looked at each other for only a moment before they rushed back into the fray. Cameron was good: he had speed and experience to go with his strength. But as the two cycled through holds and escapes, two things became clear: Roy was more practiced at hand-to-hand combat, and Cameron was the much weaker of the two. His speed and tactics kept him aloft for nearly a full minute before Roy landed a pivotal leg sweep that sent Cameron crashing down. Recovery might still have been possible if Roy hadn't learned his lesson from the first attack. Such was not the case, and Roy kept after his opponent relentlessly, offering no chance for rest. A few seconds and three taps on the ground later the first round was over.

Roy stood up and brushed himself off, extending a hand to help his younger opponent off the ground. Cameron accepted graciously, leaping up with energy to spare.

"Ready for round two?" Cameron asked with an excited smile.

"Sure, why not?" Roy now knew that there was no way Cameron could defeat him, but if the kid wanted to go again, that was fine. Chad had wasted time only to know how much time last year fighting an inferior opponent so he could learn. The least Roy could do was follow Chad's example.

"Wait a second!" A cute girl with short blonde hair came tumbling out of the crowd. Just behind her were two more freshmen, each exchanging looks of concern with the others. "Just wait a minute, please." The girl turned to Cameron, who looked as if he'd just discovered someone ate all of the cereal and put the empty box back in cupboard.

"Tell me something honestly, how much have you had to drink?" Her tone made it clear she wouldn't buck any lies or half-truths. She wanted his alcohol consumption down to the glass.

"A lot of beer," Cameron answered as honestly as he could.

"That it? Just beer? No hard liquor of any kind?"

“None at all.”

“Ugh, you’re such a moron.” The blonde began rooting around in her oversized purse, eventually producing a full bottle of what had to be the cheapest vodka sold in stores. She handed it to him without a word, and stared at him until he unscrewed the cap and began to guzzle it down.

“I’m really sorry about this,” the girl said, turning to Roy. “It’s just that with only beer he’s not going to be all that strong and I don’t want him to get hurt.”

Roy wasn’t sure what to make of that explanation or of Cameron’s chugging abilities, but he supposed at this point it made as much sense as anything else in his world. He gave her a shrug and motioned for Cameron to finish, which he did in short order.

“Thanks,” Cameron said, handing her back a now-empty bottle. He looked back at Roy with renewed vigor. “So, round two?”

## 82.

The second round started in much the same way as the first, with Cameron doing a furious charge. Roy was ready for this; he hadn't really expected the kid to learn his lesson from one loss. What he wasn't ready for was the way his blows glanced off the freshman's back, not to mention the tremendous power that Cameron struck him with. Roy hunched over and damned near lost his footing; it was only that last year of being brutally assaulted by Chad that gave him the skill to stay on his feet. Rather than going for any fancy holds, Roy merely reached over and grabbed Cameron's legs, jerking him in an arc through the air and slamming him to the ground. He should have capitalized and he knew it, but instead he took a step back to recover his bearings and his breath.

"What the fuck, kid? Where did that come from?"

Cameron came to his feet quickly, like the blow that had left a crater in Thomas's lawn hadn't even registered to his skull. There was a gentle sway to the way he stood now, the effect of speed-guzzling vodka already showing itself. He smiled at Roy, eyes a bit foggy but the intent therein still sharp as volcanic glass.

"I do love me some booze." The words slipped out just as he lurched forward, his fists flying faster than Roy would have thought possible. He got three strikes in before Roy was able to dodge and hip-toss him back to the ground.

"You're kidding me. Alcohol makes you stronger, doesn't it?" Roy glanced at the blonde who had produced the purse-vodka and saw her give a slight nod. He turned his gaze back to Cameron, who was scrambling back to his feet once more. Before the younger boy could mount another assault, Roy threw back his head and let out a tremendous bark of a laugh.

"That is fantastic!" He hunkered down into a defensive stance and met his opponent's slowly drooping eyes. "Any time you're ready."

There was a series of sounds of smacking flesh, but Chad didn't linger around to watch. He turned and walked back into the house, intent on getting some pretzels. Angela materialized at his side almost instantly; he still hadn't figured out how she moved through throngs of people with such ease.

"Don't you want to see the show?"

“No need. Roy’s going to win and I don’t think either will let things get out of hand,” Chad said.

“How can you be so sure?”

“Cameron seems to get stronger and faster with the more alcohol he consumes. However, he hasn’t gotten as strong as Roy yet, although he is a bit faster,” Chad explained.

“Fast can make the difference,” Angela tossed back. She’d seen many a match that was determined by factors other than brute force.

“It can, but there are two problems with it being a powerful enough advantage to turn the tides. For one, Roy is accustomed to fighting people who are faster than he is. During our sparring matches he grew quite adept at compensating for my faster movements. The other issue-”

“Yeah, I saw that already. Cameron is getting drunker the longer they fight.”

Chad stopped at a table in the now nearly-empty kitchen and scooped up a hand full of chips, the pretzels having been emptied out sometime earlier. “Precisely. Assuming there are no limits on how much power he can gain from alcohol, it seems he still has to contend with the side effects of intoxication.”

“You have to admit, if there’s no cap on that power it could be pretty useful.” Angela helped herself to the liquor section by mixing up a quick Mai Tai. She’d have preferred to drop some fresh fruit in it, but free booze was free booze.

“He is in the HCP at Lander. Despite what recent rumors might indicate, the standards for admission here are exceptionally high.”

“Getting into the HCP at any college is pretty difficult,” Angela pointed out. “Although I suppose we’re the only ones suffering under the stigma of doubt thanks to our recent admissions.”

“Unfounded speculation,” Chad snapped. Angela was slightly taken aback. She’d seem him shrug off all manner of trouble and insult, but this was getting under his skin. A more demure girl would have abandoned the topic immediately. A more demure girl wouldn’t have had Angela’s warrior instincts.

“It doesn’t bother you? The Poweredreds, or former Poweredreds, coming

into our school and putting us in the cross-hairs of every other member of the Hero Certification Program?”

“Not in the slightest. I have no qualms with them being here. How a person acquires their abilities doesn’t matter in the slightest. It only matters how they use them.”

“That’s quite accepting of you. And if everyone else shared that opinion, we wouldn’t have to worry about Lander looking bad.”

There was a crunching sound as Chad inadvertently disintegrated the chips he’d been holding when his hand clenched into a fist. He opened his fingers and watched a fine powder drift toward the plastic covered floor.

“Lander will come out on top. I trust Dean Blaine implicitly, and I will personally keep the reputation of this school pristine if I have to personally carry it to unseen heights. I won’t let anyone tarnish it.”

“You really love this school.” Angela handed him a paper towel to wipe off the orange chip residue. Her initial urge was to put a comforting hand on his arm; however, she immediately recognized that as a mistake. Chad would loathe pity or comfort. The most he could accept was the respect and confidence of a peer, someone truly on his level. That was why she gave him something functional instead of emotional. That was kindness he could tolerate.

“I do. I didn’t even apply to any others.”

“With your skill I guess you knew you’d get into your first pick.”

Chad shook his head. “If I’d been turned down, I would have just tried again the next year. I had to come here.”

“Look, I like Lander a lot, but I’m guessing there’s a reason for that kind of determination aside from the mild summers and beach proximity.”

“This was where my parents met. It was where all my father’s friends knew him best. When they visit and tell stories, almost all of them take place here. Every time I picture my dad, I always see him at Lander. I walk by places on campus and I remember the tales I’ve heard about his time here; I can almost picture him amongst the scenery.” Chad handed her back the now orange-stained paper towel. A lesser woman would have caved to her urges and embraced him in an enthusiastic hug. Angela accepted the towel and threw it in the trash.

“That makes sense to me. For what it’s worth, I’m glad we got you here. Nice to finally have someone who is a decent sparring partner.”

Chad gave her a rare smile, his teeth perfectly aligned and just the right shade of white. “Same to you.”

“Just one word of advice: don’t get so caught up in chasing someone else’s memories that you forget to craft your own. Someday you might have a child to pass them on to, and wouldn’t it be a shame if the only ones you could give were third-hand?”

“There is some logic to that,” Chad admitted, still facing away from her when he said it.

“Sounds like they’re finally done with the wrestling outside; let’s go make sure no one got killed,” Angela suggested. Part of a long-term offense was knowing when to retreat after a successful strike.

“That would be a bit of a mood killer,” Chad conceded. The two walked back out into the crowd, and despite its size, Angela made damn sure the tide of people wasn’t able to separate her from her date.

## 83.

With the passing of the party, all that remained for the sophomore class, aside from a few awkward wake-ups with unexpected partners the following morning and one uncomfortable break-up that resulted, were their midterm exams for Lander's standard curriculum. For some this was a source of mere annoyance, for others it was a hot ember of fear constantly searing their stomach lining. Vince fell into the latter of the two categories, but he certainly wasn't alone. He still cursed himself for the night of studying lost, to say nothing of the prodigious hangover he'd suffered the next morning. Each passing day seemed to fly by faster and faster, bringing him closer to the test that could end his career at Lander without so much as throwing a punch.

"How'd I do?" Vince's voice hadn't had this much fear in it when he was staring down George last year.

Nick made a quick mental tally of the red marks he'd drawn on Vince's paper. "Better. Definitely better. You got about fifty percent right."

Vince let out a groan that, in the right environment, would have attracted a female hyena. "That's still failing."

"True, but it is failing by less than you were when you only got thirty percent correct."

"You think that will make a difference? A fail is a fail. I have to pass this thing to stay in the HCP."

"I'm just saying you're making progress. Consistent improvement is a positive sign."

Vince flopped his body across the couch and stared up at the ceiling. "I've only got two more weeks. I've barely gotten through half the backlog of stuff I didn't really understand, and we've still got a week left of new material to cover. I don't know how I'm going to pass this class."

Nick stared at his friend's downcast face in genuine surprise. In the time they'd been at Lander he'd seen plenty of unexpected behavior from Vince, bravery in the face of impossible odds, trust when none was warranted, loyalty beyond comprehension. He'd never seen the guy downtrodden, though. Up until now, Nick wouldn't have thought Vince even knew how to accept defeat, let alone preemptively contemplate it.

“You’ll do it with lots of effort and help,” Nick reassured him. Truthfully, he only put Vince’s odds of learning the material at around forty percent, but the silver-haired warrior was too integral to their team to let go without trying to save. Besides, it was hard to picture life here without Vince. Things just wouldn’t be as interesting, or at least that’s what Nick told himself. He was still adjusting to the idea of genuine friendship, after all.

“I just don’t know,” Vince replied.

“Lucky for you I do know. This is my wheelhouse, Vince. I knew how to calculate a vig before I understood that the toilet was the place you went to shit. Math is for me what punching assholes in the face is for you. It’s what I do.”

“But that doesn’t mean you can teach me how to do it.”

“It means I’ve got a better shot than anyone else. Now, do you want to call it a day and pack your bags or do you want to go over the mistakes you made on this test?”

Vince took some time to answer, enough that Nick was almost unnerved. When he did respond, all the doubt had left his voice; in its place was the steel resolve that seemed to bubble out of him when the occasion demanded.

“Let’s review. I’m not ready to leave yet.”

\* \* \*

Roy was in unfamiliar territory. Oh sure, it seemed like a place he’d been a million times: he recognized the layout and the décor, he even felt nostalgic at the smell of paper that wafted freely through the air. Those were Hershel’s memories, not his. Hershel was the type to come to the library on a Saturday, and for any other project, Roy would have gladly let him. This was a little more personal. This was something Roy felt like he had to contribute to, otherwise it wouldn’t work.

The good thing about having Hershel’s memories was that Roy didn’t have to blunder about, hoping to find what he was looking for. He automatically knew the shelving system and was intimately familiar with several sections. Sadly, the book he was looking for wasn’t science fiction or fantasy, so the latter knowledge wasn’t as useful as the former. Before long, Roy found his destination, rows and rows of books all crammed with tidbits and facts from the span of human history. A special area of these shelves was



dedicated to a subject most people found frequently fascinating, especially given the special curriculum it was known that Lander offered. These books were all about Supers and Heroes, ranging from autobiographies to sheer speculation. Roy loaded up his arms with a few choice selections and found a table where he set up shop.

He'd take home as many as he could, but first he needed to weed through the ones that didn't cover his topic of interest. A quick perusal disqualified several selections, not for their style but for their substance; they only dealt with Supers whose powers were unlike Roy's.

A better understanding of his own abilities was key; that's what Professor Fletcher had told him. So far the private tutoring sessions weren't working. Roy was still at the same weight he had been months ago. That was why he was wasting a beautiful afternoon surrounding himself with books. If understanding was key, then learning about everyone else whose abilities resembled his own seemed like a logical jumping off point. When Hershel took back over and looked at these memories, he would find himself surprisingly proud of his muscular brother.

More books were read and set aside. Roy was beginning to notice a pattern: while people like himself frequently dotted the landscape of Hero history, they rarely took center stage. Strongman was just a role people had in groups, much like healers. They were useful, but ultimately ancillary. After all, lifting a car was impressive to humans, but it didn't quite have the shine of turning oxygen into atomic energy. The more he searched, the more frustrated he became. His whole suite of powers was merely an accoutrement for some Supers, a small piece of what they could do. It began to make sense why Chad was so defensive about his abilities: he didn't want to get lumped in with people who couldn't really do anything besides give and receive powerful punches.

There were exceptions, of course: a few like Roy who had risen high in the esteem of the public and Hero community alike. These he took note of and set their books in the checkout pile. The last book he read concerned possibly the most famous strongman in recent history, one whose abilities bore a striking similarity to Roy's. This book was immediately set in the discard pile and left abandoned as Roy gathered his selections and headed for the front desk. In truth, it was a testament to his emotional growth over the past year that the book was not thrown with enough force to send it through the well. Still, regardless of how useful the information contained within might be, there was simply no way Roy would be rifling through that book's

contents.

In Roy's opinion, he already knew far too much about its main subject, a Hero named Titan.

## 84.

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport did not, to their credit, fidget as they waited in Dean Blaine's office. They had attended far too many clandestine meetings in locations much scarier than this one to let their nerves show so easily. That said, neither man felt quite as confident as he normally would have. Some Supers looked at their abilities as a gift that was made more special by using it rarely; others considered their talents a useful skill in their day-to-day lives. Then you had Supers like the two men wearing suits and purposely not fidgeting, Supers who used their abilities so often that being denied access to them was akin to temporarily removing a leg. It was possible to still stand, even to have some sense of mobility, but it left them precariously off-balance.

Dean Blaine popped open the door and strode in without so much as a glance in their direction. He carried a stack of papers in one hand and a cup of coffee that seemed dangerously close to spilling over in the other. After a bit of brief involuntarily juggling, he managed to deposit everything on his desk and take a seat. Still, it was only after a long draw of java that he turned his attention to the men he had summoned for this meeting.

"You'll forgive the mess, things are a bit busy preparing for the various classes' exams. The freshman's labyrinth is particularly time-consuming."

Both men nodded their understanding. Despite the way the HCP staff liked to make things seem effortless, they had experience enough to know that crafting that illusion just took all the more time and energy.

"I've called you here for a brief comparison of notes. As you may know, I've been to see George multiple times and all I've managed to pull from him are sarcastic barbs and cryptic allusions. I know your company has been looking into the incident as well and I'm hoping they have managed to have a bit more luck."

Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport very much did not exchange a conspiratorial glance. Instead, Mr. Numbers resettled in his chair and addressed the question.

"I won't say they haven't found a few clues; however, that doesn't mean they've shared them with us. As you may recall we aren't exactly

considered exemplary employees these days.”

“Yet you retain your posts.”

“Only through very exceptional fortune and a lot of effort to make things better,” Mr. Numbers pointed out.

“You misunderstand. I don’t mean that because you retain your posts I expect that the company still trusts you. I mean that because you are still tasked with watching over those students I expect your company to give you some warning if they have any idea who might be knocking down the door to Melbrook Hall.”

“I wish they thought that way,” Mr. Transport mumbled.

“What my partner means is that despite the logic of your argument, we were given this assignment specifically because we are thought capable enough to handle any situation without the aid of a warning.”

“Just like you did last year,” Dean Blaine said, his voice pleasant but his eyes growing steadily less friendly.

“Do try to remember that our original assignment was not so much to protect our charges from the world as it was vice versa,” Mr. Numbers said. “Keeping them safe was always a priority, of course.”

“Yes, but only in the general sense. So long as most of them were okay then it was all right to let a small number be lost.”

“That was the company’s stance,” Mr. Transport agreed. “If you recall, it wasn’t ours.”

Dean Blaine realized he’d been inching forward in his seat as the discussion progressed. He leaned back and took another sip of his coffee to calm down. Over-protectiveness could be a good trait in a person who watched over children, but it had to be focused properly. There was no sense in getting angry at two men over policies they’d nearly lost their jobs in defying, especially when they might have information that could prove vital to his efforts.

“You’re right; I apologize,” Dean Blaine said. “I suppose I’m just frustrated. After all these months we still have almost no idea who was pulling the strings behind George and Persephone.”

Mr. Numbers resisted the urge to tilt his head forward in interest.

“Almost no idea?”

“George has claimed it was everyone from the President of the United States to one of the janitors up on the main campus. He has only given me one hint that seemed like it might be more valid than the others. That’s what I was hoping to confirm in this meeting.”

A flick of the tongue across his teeth was the only sign Mr. Numbers showed of the internal war currently being waged. Information was a currency in his world, something to guard and protect more fervently than gold. Money could always be reclaimed, but once a secret was out there was no hope of gaining a refund. Still, Dean Blaine had defended them when interviewed by the company’s agents. It had taken a lot of research to uncover this fact for certain, but Mr. Numbers knew it to be true. If there was one thing he loathed more than giving away information for free, it was being in someone’s debt. Besides, he wouldn’t mind seeing just how deep the hole George crawled out of went.

“There is one thing. They never said anything specifically; however, about a month ago, one of our fellow agents showed up while the students were in class. She installed a specialized wire system through all the outer walls, one set to trigger an alarm under very specific circumstances. We were instructed that if that alarm should go off, we would do well to grab all the students we can and teleport to a pre-determined location immediately.”

“All the students you can.” Dean Blaine gulped down more coffee and stayed his temper. What they were told and what they did could be very different things. “So, what were the circumstances that would set off the alarm?”

“She didn’t tell us,” Mr. Transport admitted.

“I did a little digging afterward,” Mr. Numbers added. “As near as I can tell, the wires are programmed to detect when any part of the outer walls are destroyed without registering significant heat or impact.”

“An alarm tripped by disintegration,” Dean Blaine surmised. “That is... unfortunate.”

“I don’t suppose you’d like to make this a two-way street of sharing and tell us what it means,” Mr. Transport said.

Dean Blaine rose from his desk and walked to the bookshelf. His finger slid along the spines of many selections before stopped at a thick

leather one. A deft hand plucked it from the shelf and nimble fingers rifled through the pages with effortless dexterity.

“What I am going to tell you stays in the strictest confidence. It seems one of my old classmates is either running this game or is at least another pawn in it. Unfortunately it is one I had hoped I’d never have to contend with again.”

The book made a damp thud as Dean Blaine set it on the desk. He pointed to a picture in the upper right-hand corner, one of himself and a smiling young man both clutching diplomas high overhead in a sign of victory.

“Gerard Cooper, better known to the world as Raze, has returned.”

## 85.

Nick flipped through the pages once more, almost willing them to hold more correct answers than they previously had. Sadly, his desire was no match for reality and the white paper was still doused liberally in red ink. It had been over a week of constant study, practice, and effort, all of which had yielded an increase from getting fifty percent of the questions right to fifty-five percent. If he and Vince had possessed infinite time it would have been an encouraging trend, but with a week left, it was only slightly less depressing than a death sentence.

There wasn't blame to be thrown about either, except perhaps at the education Vince had received as a child. Both students had burned the candle at both ends trying to bring him up to speed in time for the test; however, this particular branch of math was like a foreign language to Vince. Even if he could get a grip on the vocabulary, he was lost when it came to tenses and conjugation. The guy might know more about fighting and surviving on the run than anyone else Nick had ever encountered, but it was becoming very clear that any type of advanced math was a lost cause.

"Looks like we're going to Plan B," Nick mumbled to himself. He sat alone in his room, illuminated only by the light of a small desk lamp and his monitor. Vince's latest series of practice exams sat scattered on his lap, confirming the fear he'd been nursing since beginning their endeavor. If it had been anyone else in this situation they would have been thoroughly screwed. No passing grade on the test meant lower than a C in the class, which would get one immediately booted from the HCP. This policy had endured since the inception of the HCP, despite many protests from educators that it was unnecessarily harsh. Someone in Vince's situation was effectively looking down the barrel of a gun aimed directly at all their dreams. With hard work proving a failure, he didn't see any options left. Nick, on the other hand, was not so limited in his range of tactics.

He'd been laying the groundwork for this scheme since the first time he saw Vince struggle through a few practice problems. It would be time-consuming, and possibly expensive, but it would work. At the moment that was all that mattered. Nick needed Vince on their team, not just because of his constantly-growing skill level but because he brought a certain amount of heart to their efforts. The kid was inspiring, at least to those who were prone to inspiration. Losing both a competent warrior and a force to rally the troops

was an unacceptable cost to playing by the rules. So Nick would do what Nicholas Campbell did better than anyone else.

He would cheat.

\* \* \*

Jill's phone began vibrating again, rattling across the table's rough wooden surface. She silenced it without a thought, but not before Will noticed.

"How many times does that make so far?" He didn't look up from the book he was making notes in, didn't even pause the careful stroke of his highlighter.

"Four," Jill lied. It had been seven, but she'd caught the signals from the others before the phone had been obvious in its tremors. Jill's own book was far less written in than Will's; her mind had been elsewhere since their cram session began.

"Four calls in the span of three hours. That seems a bit excessive."

"He probably forgot we made plans to study and wants to grab dinner," Jill defended.

"It's past nine. He must be a late eater." Will didn't accuse outwardly; even his tone was completely neutral. It wasn't his way to seem judgmental. He knew Jill well enough to understand that would send her running in the opposite direction just to be contrary.

"Glenn is excitable. When he wants to do or share something with me he just gets persistent. That's all."

"Of course." Jill and Glenn had been dating for three weeks now, ever since meeting in class, and Will had disliked him for two weeks and six days. He was semi-good looking and seemed affable enough, but there was something in his eyes that Will didn't trust. There was an edge of obsession, and the possessive way Glenn had gripped Will's sister's hand left the twin brother with his teeth on edge. Jill had a habit for picking the ones who tried to hold her just a bit too tightly, a trait not uncommon in children who suffered abuse in their formative years.

The phone buzzed across the table again. This time Jill didn't silence it; instead she flipped it open and got up from her chair. Will sat quietly, continuing his work, allowing her to relocate without so much as a glance. He



could pick up snippets of the conversation, hushed reassurances like “I told you I had to study” and “Yes, I’m with my brother”. Soon she would come into the room and feign a headache or some such nonsense and say she needed to go back to her dorm. She’d actually go to see Glenn, and if Will was a betting man, he’d put down twenty dollars that Glenn would spend the night passive-aggressively making her feel like shit for having any priorities in life other than him. She was lonely and Glenn could be nice when he wanted to be. Will understood; he’d read all the psychology texts long ago. Will didn’t blame her for falling into these patterns. He didn’t even blame Glenn for being an asshole.

Will blamed himself. If he’d acted sooner, if he’d been quicker to grasp the situation when they were kids, maybe he could have gotten her out of their mother’s house before things had reached the point they did. He had no excuses for his failure, only regret and a burning desire never to see it repeated.

“I’m pretty beat. I think I’m going to head home so I can actually wake up in time for my morning class,” Jill said as she walked back into the kitchen. She began putting her books away immediately, stuffing them indiscriminately in her backpack with no regard for which papers belonged in which books.

“Sure thing. Think you’ll want to study again sometime before finals?”

“I’m positive I’ll need it. I’ll give you a call when I think I have a free night.” Jill finished her haphazard packing job and gave her brother a quick hug. “Love you, Bro.”

“Love you, too.” Will let her leave without objection; no words he had would rectify the situation. Instead he closed the book he’d been working in and pulled out a black spiral. Inside were schematics and calculations that would have given a hard-on to any corporate engineer who laid eyes on them. Will rifled to the last page, where a new design was still incomplete. It seemed he needed to work faster than expected on it; he’d expected the relationship’s escalation to be more gradual.

Will’s pencil danced across the page, quickly filling the gaps in the design. By tomorrow night he could start the building process. He’d move fast, stay up until dawn if need be. It would be ready. He would be ready. His only regret in life was moving too slowly the first time. Will was determined that there would never be a second time, regardless of what preventing it

might cost him.

## 86.

Testing season commenced across Lander with a flurry of final all-nighters and a run on energy drinks at the surrounding gas stations. The exams were spread across a three-day period, allowing for some recovery time if a one had a fortunate schedule and a gauntlet of intellectual trials if one were not so lucky. As the days advanced, the populace dwindled, students hightailing it back home on winter break as soon as their final blue book had been handed off to a sullen TA. By the final day only a smattering remained; those who had tests on the last day were cursed or blessed depending on whether they prized the extra study time over the chance to take an early leave.

Vince counted himself in the blessed category as he pored over a practice test, eyes darting between failed problems and the steady progress of the clock on the wall. He was so engrossed he didn't even notice the sound of the front lounge door opening as Nick entered, backpack slung low over his shoulder.

"Damn it, Vince. I thought we talked about last-minute cramming."

Vince jumped in surprise, knocking his knee against the wooden table. He let out a mumbled curse and turned toward Nick, who was glaring at him like a father who had just caught his son looking through brochures for ballet schools.

"I know. I'm sorry. I just couldn't resist trying to figure out a few things I missed."

"A brain is just like any other muscle." Nick crossed the room in a few long-legged strides and snatched away Vince's papers. "You can't burn it out right before you need it to perform at peak capacity. Train and heal. How is it you can understand that when it comes to exercise but not studying?"

Vince grinned sheepishly. "In all honesty I'm not that good at resting when it comes to exercise either."

"Why does that not surprise me?" Nick folded the papers and stuffed them in his back pocket. "Okay look, it's noon right now. Your test is at two, right?"

"Yeah."

“Then you are going to do some mindless bullshit until half past one. Television, porn, even comic books. I don’t care, just go and strain your brain no more.” Nick’s tone and body language made it clear that this was an order, not a request. Normally Vince might have balked a bit more, but Nick had put in countless hours over the last few weeks helping him study. After all that work, if Nick thought he needed to rest, then Vince would trust him.

“Okay. I’ll go watch a movie.” Vince got up from his chair and started toward the boys’ side lounge.

“If I knock on your door and see you with a book open, you and I are going to have it out,” Nick called after him. It was purely for show: Vince was one of the few people who did what he said he would do, situation regardless. Besides, Nick still had his own work to complete; he didn’t have time to check in on Vince. He’d wrapped up his own final exam in exceptional time, even by his standards. He needed the hour before Vince left to finish the last of the arrangements. Most of the prep work had gone smoothly enough, but Nick knew far too well that things could fall apart at the last minute if one let details slide.

He walked back to the common room’s front door and hefted it open. Two figures walked in immediately, neither looking particularly cheerful at having been left in the entrance hall. Some of the sentiment might have been bitterness: this was their first time seeing Melbrook and its impressive accommodations. Both of them were in the HCP as well, yet they were confined to standard dorm rooms like all the other students.

“Vince should be effectively distracted,” Nick informed them. “Are there any questions before we start our operation?”

Neither Adam nor Rich spoke, which made Nick quite happy. Last-minute questions were a symptom of poor communication, and Nick did not engage in such a sloppy practice as poor communication.

“Excellent. If everyone is ready then let’s go to work.”

\* \* \*

Vince walked nervously into the classroom and grabbed a seat near the middle of the desks. He glanced around and saw the rest of the class seemed to look more certain than him. No one else was fidgeting with their pencil and looking to the heavens for hope, anyway. He’d barely gotten settled when the professor breezed in the door with a stack of papers in hand. He dropped half of them on the desk of his TA and within a few moments all the tests were

disseminated through the class.

“You have one hour to complete the exam. Those who are unable to finish will turn in what they have completed when time is out. Good luck. You may begin.”

Vince swallowed a fresh wave of fear and turned over the first page. A small sense of relief tickled his brain as he realized he knew how to work the beginning set of problems. It made sense: this was what they’d first covered so it was the building block to the rest of the class. He might not understand everything, but he’d drilled himself hard enough on the basics to be capable of working through them.

The next page revealed more questions he was able to handle, and the one after that, and the one after that. As the minutes ticked by, Vince found a sense of optimism blooming in his chest. He wasn’t getting every single problem; however, he was by far knocking out the majority of them. When he finished the last page, he glanced up at the clock and realized he still had half an hour left. Vince turned the book over and began to recheck his answers with the remaining minutes, though for the most part it was a futile gesture. For the first time in weeks he was feeling genuinely confident.

He turned in his test and exited with a smile. He’d done it. Vince had no doubt he had passed that monster of a class. A joyful whistle escaped his lips as he exited the math building and never looked back.

\* \* \*

A silver-haired boy slunk into the classroom quietly, dropping his backpack at a desk near the back of the room. A quick glance around showed nervous faces anxiously studying notecards and practice tests as the final seconds ticked away. There was a rapid shuffle of papers as the professor walked in and nodded to his TA, who immediately rose from her desk and began handing out the tests.

“You will have one hour to complete the exam. If there are any questions, you may come speak to me at my desk. Any unfinished problems at the end of the time limit will be counted as incorrect answers. I wish you all the best of luck. Please begin.”

The room was filled with the scratching of pencil lead as students made furious calculations and deductions, slowly working their way through each page. The first student, a bright girl with dark hair, was done within twenty minutes. After her departure, a paced parade of students made their

way to the desk, dropping their exams off along with a hopeful glance and a softly mumbled prayer. The silver-haired boy was among the last to finish, walking to the desk only five minutes before time ran out.

“Feel confident, Vince?” The professor had taken a bit of a liking to this student; his poor grasp of concept was redeemed by the focus and dedication he showed day after day in class.

“I feel like I did everything I could. That’s the best any one of us can offer.”

The two exchanged a friendly smile and the professor turned his attention back to the remaining students. Soon time would be up and then the results would come out.

## 87.

Mary perched on Hershel's bed as he haphazardly hurled various clothes into his worn suitcase. The early morning sun streamed through his window, illuminating the mess of clothes that betrayed Hershel's procrastination in packing. Tests had wrapped up yesterday and Mr. Transport was teleporting everyone except Alice home in about half an hour. This had required multiple assurances on the part of both Mr. Transport and Mr. Numbers that their journey home wouldn't go by way of a mountain-climb. If not for their help at the end of last year, it was doubtful any of the students would have gambled on the trip, but between the budding trust and the supreme convenience, most had elected to take the chance.

"Am I mistaken, or are you only packing dirty clothes?" Mary noted that while the distinction between the two was largely up to interpretation, it did seem that only the most wrinkled and stained garments were making it into the suitcase.

"Yeah. Not much sense in washing clean ones at home."

"I'm sure your mother will appreciate that."

Hershel paused the rain of clothes to stick his tongue out at Mary. "I do my own laundry, thank you very much. I just prefer the ease of using the washer at my house to the ones in the laundromat."

"Ah yes." The laundry facilities at the Lander dorms were much like the ones in every other college basement. They worked in the sense that they left clothes wetter than when they came in and smelling faintly of soap, but to call anything produced from them clean was something of a stretch. "I might need to rethink my own suitcase composition."

"You might be a little short on time for that," Hershel pointed out.

"Oh, only you're allowed to cram clothes at the last minute?"

"I've got more practice. This sort of thing is an art."

"Mmmhmm. You could just say you prefer me to stay with you until we leave, seeing as we won't be together again for nearly three weeks."

"Okay, then. Yes. That." Hershel took another break from his rush, but this time it was to kiss his girlfriend rather than sass her. Mary responded with

enthusiastic affection, and it was only the impending departure time that forced Hershel to pull back from the girl he so evidently adored.

“You’re sure you’ll be okay, right?” All the flippancy was gone from his voice, in its place lay naked concern.

“I’m positive,” Mary reassured him. “Mr. Numbers arranged for some people to keep an eye on me during the break. I might look like I’m alone but I’ll always have protection.”

“Alice’s place is still safer, and I’m sure she’d love to have you.”

“I know she would, but I’m not going to spend my life hiding from whoever these people are. It’s Christmas, and I’m going to see my family. I already had this fight with Alice, and I wound up convincing her to come visit me instead. We’ll be fine, Hershel, I promise.”

“Be sure you are,” he replied. “Otherwise I’m going to miss a lot of school hunting you down.”

“If you don’t hurry you’ll be spending a lot of time on a bus to Chicago.”

“I’m relatively certain Mr. Transport won’t leave without me,” Hershel said, turning his attention back to the clothes. “I think he’s scared of my mom.”

\* \* \*

Mr. Transport did indeed look a bit nervous as he sat in the living room and periodically glanced at his watch. Whether that was related to seeing Ms. Daniels or a general regard for punctuality would be speculation to anyone but Mary, who wasn’t listening to thoughts at the moment. Neither Vince nor Alice paid his intermittently-shaking foot any regard: both were absorbed in last-minute luggage checks as they gathered their things by the common room couch. The only one who might have caught on was Nick, and he was occupied with a different mystery as he entered the building.

“So,” he said, swaggering through the door from the entrance hall, “I went to do a last-minute mail check and look what was sitting by the door.” From behind his back Nick produced a small parcel wrapped in blue paper with cartoon snowmen patterned about. A light red ribbon topped the present along with small tag that presumably bore the name of its intended recipient.

“It seems some anonymous person wanted to wish Alice a Merry



Christmas,” Nick continued, purposely answering the obvious question before anyone else could ask it.

“Me?”

“Unless there is another Alice Adair at this residence.” Nick walked over and set the gift down in front of her. Rather than reaching for it she merely stared in disbelief.

“Should we get it checked or something? I mean, we’ve been targeted before.”

“Mary was targeted,” Mr. Numbers corrected from the kitchen. “And I sincerely doubt even the most enthusiastic critic of Poweredreds has the gumption to send you something dangerous.”

“We could still get it looked at, just to be sure. I know a guy in my study group with X-ray vision,” Vince offered.

“No, Mr. Numbers is right,” Alice replied. She plucked the present from the table and quickly tore through the paper to reveal a plain brown box. A swift slice of her well-manicured nail destroyed the tape binding it together. Her hands carefully pulled open the top flaps and she peered inside slowly.

“So what is it?” Vince asked.

“Glitter.” Alice’s tone was no less dumbfounded than the uncertain look on her face. She pulled out a small plastic tube that sparkled with pink light. “It’s ten tubes of colored glitter, the kind you can put on like make-up.”

“You don’t generally wear glitter,” Nick noted.

“Only when I’m rocking a particularly sparkly top or dress and it pulls the look together,” Alice agreed.

“Maybe the person thought you should wear more?” Vince suggested.

“Great, now I have strangers giving me fashion advice.” Alice’s tone seemed curt, yet Nick noticed she carefully tucked the box into her luggage, making extra sure it was secure.

“Would someone please go check on Hershel?” Mr. Transport interrupted. “We’re due to leave very soon.”

“I’ll go see if he needs help,” Vince volunteered. Mr. Transport nodded and tried to push down his jangling nerves. Whatever was bothering

him seemed to only be getting worse the closer they drew to departure.

Nick was the first to be deposited at home, and he breathed a soft sigh of relief as the dry scorching air of Vegas enveloped him. Despite his own assessments, Nick still hadn't been one hundred percent sure Mr. Transport wasn't going to drop them in some dangerous environment and leave them to survive. He'd been quite close to certain, but Nick was nothing if not a firm advocate in never believing one knew exactly how things would transpire. The element of doubt left room for back-up plans and improvisation. It was what separated a good tactician from a great one.

He sauntered down The Strip at a leisurely pace, glancing at the casino fronts to note any changes that had happened in his absence. It had only been a few months, but that was the nature of Vegas. It was constantly shifting, always striving to be novel so that no visitor had quite the same experience two trips in a row. Change was the only constant, a philosophy Nick had embraced many years ago.

As he dragged his suitcase up the sidewalk to his own casino, Nick was surprised to see a familiar face standing by the door. Gerry was generally dispatched to personally handle high-rollers and problems. As their eyes met and Gerry started forward Nick took a guess this was a case of the latter.

"Good to see you, Campbell."

"You, too. Want to tell me why I'm getting a handshake at the door?"

Gerry adjusted his tie, a tactic he used when he wanted to scan an area without being overt. After a moment of ensuring no prying ears were about, he leaned in close. "The Evers kid is back in town. He's at one of the poker tables cleaning the spare change out of every tourist who sits down."

Nick crinkled his nose in distaste. The Evers were a family similar to the Pips; they had separate holdings but Vegas was a place where such assets butted against one another. Nathaniel Evers wasn't part of the line that might end up being at the head of the family, but he was definitely being groomed for a leadership position. He was smart, cunning, and positively ruthless. Even worse, he was a Super. Nathaniel and Nicholas had run into one another several times throughout their lives, and the relationship was not exactly what one might call cordial.

Nicholas Campbell looked down at his Lander costume, a t-shirt and

dusty jeans that he would have rather been killed in than seen here in. “I need to change.”

“That’s why I met you at the door. We’ll go around to the service entrance.”

Nicholas followed Gerry, despite knowing damned well no one would have stopped him if he’d gone through the back by himself. There was propriety to observe, however, and one never knew when someone from the Nevada Gaming Commission was watching. They were vulnerable to bribery, of course, but there was no need to incur unnecessary expenses. The two made it to the elevator without encountering anyone besides a bellboy and a chef, Gerry punching in the numbers then leaving to go back to the floor.

The floors flashed by quickly as Nicholas stood alone in the rising elevator. He’d need to take his time and truly let go of the current character. There was no room for Nick when dealing with Nathaniel; only Nicholas Campbell could handle that level of opponent. A small smile tugged at the corner of his mouth as he drew nearer to his destination. It had been four years since their last encounter, one that had found them quite evenly matched. A lot had changed in four years. Nicholas was curious to see how they measured against one another now that they were both Supers, even if his new status was a secret.

He suspected it would be quite interesting.

\* \* \*

Alice’s silver car didn’t bother to slow down as it neared the exit that would carry her into the subdivision where her father’s estate sprawled. Instead she kept her foot on the gas, accelerating a few more miles down the highway. When she did exit it was onto a road that was surrounded by dense foliage. Lush trees dotted the roadway with only the occasional homes interspersed between them. She navigated through the worn roads carefully, being certain never to go above the posted speed-limit. Eventually she pulled into a parking lot adjacent to a wrought-iron fence. It was still early in the afternoon, so the gate stood wide open to welcome all crossing its threshold.

Alice cut a leisurely pace across the cobblestone paths, savoring the scent of fresh flowers that permeated the landscape. Some people were disturbed by places like this, seeing the constant marble markers as harbingers of their inevitable death. This particular establishment took great pains to inspire a sense of tranquility over trepidation; however, that was only a part of

why Alice felt at ease here. Growing up her home had seemed more tomblike than this place, the empty halls and echoing sounds creating an atmosphere of hollowness. Here there was feeling; here people wept openly and talked freely, even if no one was physically there to listen. Here there was, ironically enough, life.

Alice found her way to the modest headstone quite easily. She'd visited this place a lot in her youth, however her time at Lander had made such trips more infrequent. At one point she might have felt guilty about it, but as she'd grown, she had come to realize that her mother would probably have been happy that Alice possessed such a full life that she had less time to visit.

"Hey, Mom," Alice said as she plopped down onto the grass. "It's been a while. I hope things have been nice out here." Looking at the headstone, one would never guess that this was the resting place of a multi-billionaire's wife. That had been her way. She loved simplicity and nature. It always amazed Alice that Charles Adair had given her the grave she would have wanted, not the one he felt she deserved. It was a testament to how much he'd loved her; Alice's father was not prone to doing things other people's way.

"Things at school have been complicated, but hey, what else is new..." Alice sat talking to her mother until the fireflies began to dart through the sky. When she finally left, it was with grass-stained pants and a much lighter heart.

\* \* \*

Mr. Transport's hands felt sweaty as he appeared at the home of Hershel and Roy Daniels. This was the final stop of the day; he'd already deposited Mary in the quiet suburb where her parents resided. Since there was no geographic limitation to where he teleported, the order in which he dispensed his charges had been entirely up to him. It was for this reason he'd chosen to leave Vince and Hershel for last, and it factored in greatly to the phantom sensation of sweat saturating his palms despite their dry status.

"Hey, Mom," Hershel greeted, dropping his bag on the ground and embracing his mother in a strong hug.

"Good afternoon, Ms. Daniels," Vince said politely. The seemingly docile woman had threatened him with extensive bodily harm if he dared try to spend Christmas on his own as he had last year. He often wondered how a single woman could exude both fastidious decorum and soul-rending

intimidation. Had he grown up in the south, he would have understood.

“So good to see both of you,” Ms. Daniels said warmly. “Thank you for bringing them by, Mr. Transport.”

“Always a pleasure,” Mr. Transport replied. “If you have a moment, I wanted to speak with you on coordinating their return trip.”

“Of course. Boys, why don’t you bring your bags up to Hershel’s room and we can see about getting supper started?”

Vince and Hershel complied automatically, dragging their suitcases up the stairs in a flurry of quick movements that only the young and enthusiastic can manage so easily.

“Class resumes on the sixth for them, so I assume you’ll want to pick them up on the fifth,” Ms. Daniels said, a good measure of the warmth leaving her voice as the boys vacated the room. “Or is there an HCP activity they need to be back early for?”

“No, it runs parallel with the actual Lander schedule so the fifth should be fine.” Mr. Transport licked his lips, which had suddenly become strangely dry. There was no putting it off any longer; if he wanted to take action he had to strike now. He wouldn’t likely get a better opportunity. “Actually, there was something else I wanted to speak with you on.”

“Oh? Anything to do with last year’s incident?”

“Nothing like that. I was just wondering if you’d allow me to take you out to dinner.”

Ms. Daniels was not an easily surprised woman, yet the wide-eyed look across her face said quite clearly that Mr. Transport had succeeded in catching her off-guard.

“I beg your pardon?”

“I want to take you on a date, if you’re willing,” Mr. Transport reiterated.

“May I ask what motivated this? Our interactions have not exactly been cordial.”

“Curiously, that’s a good part of why I’m asking you out. My job makes sustaining a relationship very difficult. In my experience, it only has a chance of working with strong, capable women. Plus, I do find you rather

attractive.”

Ms. Daniels didn't blush: she hadn't done anything so juvenile in many years. She did, however, mentally move a step back and take a fresh look at Mr. Transport. He was tall and lean, a bit more haggard than she liked her men, truthfully. He did cut a nice figure in the hand-tailored black suit, and she was long beyond the mindset that physicality was the only factor that mattered in a possible partner. With the exception of the mountain training, he'd done an excellent job of looking over the children, and Vince had spoken to her over the summer of the great risk he took in helping save Hershel. He seemed a nice enough sort, and the teleportation ability probably meant they could go somewhere other than the god-awful Italian restaurant around the corner.

“Let's exchange phone numbers,” Ms. Daniels said at last. “I'll have my hands full with Hershel, Roy, and Vince over the break, but afterward I could probably find a free night for dinner.”

Despite the fact that his hands were still quite dry, Mr. Transport still nearly dropped his cell phone in his hurry to pull it free from his pants pocket.

There was no snow in southern California on Christmas day; in fact, Charles Adair found himself fiddling with the air conditioning as he settled down to work in his study. It was a rare holiday indeed that allowed Charles to be at home; however, on this occasion his meetings had lined up in a way that it made the most sense to work from his mansion for a few days. There was a Christmas tree in the foyer and some lights along the railing, but that had all been put up by a service Charles paid for maintenance and decoration. Charles had no concern for Christmas beyond the fact that it meant his American business contacts were out of commission for a few days. He was not a festive man. Not since a great many years ago.

Charles worked through the morning without pause, taking care of documents that had accumulated over the past few weeks. Some needed review, others authorization, but all were of exceptional importance. If they weren't then they never would have made it all the way to his large, expensive desk. His pen scratched across the papers as the clock ticked away. Charles paid it no concern; he threw himself into his work as he always had. He was so engrossed that it would have been impossible for him to say how long he been at it before he was interrupted by a sound at his door. Charles paused his writing and glanced up to deal with the disturbance.

As soon as his eyes fell upon the door, Charles let out a choked, strangled sound from deep in his throat. A ghost stared back at him, her dazzling green eyes accentuated by pink glitter liberally swiped across her eyelids. He felt his mouth open and close repeatedly. Dimly he was aware of a wet sensation in his hand.

"Daddy, did you hear me? They're going to have lunch ready soon. You should come eat." Alice gazed at him with concern. She wore a sundress that was wrong for the season and right for the weather. Her hair was pulled back into a ponytail, drawing all the more attention to the sparkling around her eyes.

"I...yes, of course." Charles blinked several times and reasserted his grip on reality. On the subject of grips, he realized he'd crushed his pen, the spilling ink accounting for the dampness he'd felt on his hand.

"Are you okay? You look flustered."



“I’m fine, it’s just the glitter...” Charles shook his head once for good measure and looked about for a towel to wipe his now-stained hand on. “Sorry, Alice, sometimes I forget how much you look like your mother.”

“Did Mom wear glitter?”

Charles laughed, but not with his business appropriate laugh or his boys’ club laugh or even his polite disapproval laugh. Charles Adair let out a genuine expelling of mirth. Alice couldn’t remember ever hearing anything quite like it before.

“She wore glitter all the damned time. I can scarcely remember a day when she didn’t have some on. I tried to get her to ease up a little; it got on everything and was impossible to scrub away. She refused, of course. She used to tell me, ‘Glitter is a form of anti-depressant, because it is impossible to be sad when you twinkle.’”

“That sounds... cheerful.” Alice wasn’t sure what tone her voice had right now. Charles never talked about his deceased wife, and Alice didn’t want him to stop now that he’d let a bit of her memory slip free.

“I suppose it does. To her credit, she might have been right about the glitter. I’ve never known a consistently happier person than your mother.” Charles gave up the search for a towel; he was the only one allowed in this room and he knew he didn’t keep one here. With a minor exertion of will, he changed the ink into water and wiped the moisture off onto his slacks. “I think I will join you for lunch. I’m a bit peckish today.”

“I’ll tell the chefs,” Alice volunteered.

“No, I’ll go with you. I need to get a towel to clean the remaining ink off my desk anyway.” Charles stood from the table and looked at his daughter once more. “It really is shocking how similar you two are. What motivated the eye glitter today, anyway?”

“I got some as a Christmas present from... a friend,” Alice lied. “Since today is a holiday I thought I’d make myself a little extra festive.”

“Well, it looks good on you,” Charles said. The two left the room and began traversing the mansion’s vast halls as the West Coast sun continued to beat down on the world outside.

\* \* \*

Chicago had plenty of snow and cold for the season, so much so that it

easily could have shared with other cities. A fresh inch cascaded down in fierce flurries as two figures trudged their way down the street. One was shorter and husky, the other seemed to have accrued so much snow that it had turned his hair silver. They plodded on methodically, checking street signs at each intersection to make certain they hadn't lost their way.

"I still can't believe my cousins knocked all the gravy on the floor," Hershel mumbled, just barely audible over the persistent wind smacking them in the face.

"They didn't mean to. They were just playing," Vince defended.

"Playing in the kitchen near all the bowls where they aren't allowed."

"Your mom said all she needed was a base and she could make more in half an hour."

"I'm not doubting my mother's culinary abilities nor the willingness of my family to wait. I'm just annoyed because I have to freeze my butt off out here."

"A quick drink could have let Roy out," Vince suggested.

Hershel shook his head. "My mom's side of the family is all normal. They know about Roy, but they're a little put off by him. Roy tends to act out in situations where he feels like he's being judged."

"I take it they don't get along."

"There have been some strained holidays," Hershel said something else, but Vince missed it thanks to a particularly fierce burst of wind. On instinct he turned to look back from where they'd come; Vince's years wandering had made the ability to retrace steps a survival instinct. What he saw was rows upon rows of distinct houses being drowned out by an ever-thickening shower of white.

Vince squinted his eyes a bit. There was something else there, too, a human figure a block or two back. He couldn't make out any details, not even a sex, but there was something about the figure that tickled the base of Vince's brain. He stopped his forward movement and could have sworn the figure stopped walking as well.

"Vince! For the third time, are you okay?"

"Huh?" Vince whipped back around to Hershel, who was looking both

concerned and frosty.

“You spaced out on me and kept staring behind us. I thought maybe the cold was getting to you.”

“I thought I saw something.” Vince turned back around, only to find the snow-saturated street was empty save for himself and Hershel. “I guess I was wrong.”

“The light can play some crazy tricks when it bounces off the snow. Let’s hurry and get Mom the flour for the gravy before we really do get lost in this storm,” Hershel said.

“Right.” The two quickened their pace, hurrying toward the store. Several blocks away, two other figures stepped out from the alley beside a house and watched them go. Some moments later there was a bright light that danced across the falling flakes, and then the sidewalk was unoccupied once more.

## 90.

Nicholas sat at a table on a balcony overlooking the casino; the last vestiges of a superb steak dinner and half a glass of red wine rested in front of him. Normally he would have taken Christmas lunch with Gerry; however, the older man had been swept up in handling a high-roller's concerns for discretion and security. There wasn't really anyone else it would be appropriate to mix with; the casino owner's nephew could be seen buying waitresses drinks and slinking off to their room without issue. Spending a holiday together, that was a level of familiarity that spoke of more closeness than anyone outside of a small circle was privy to.

He heard the chair next to him pull out and the weight settle into it without turning from his view of the slot machines below. There was no need to look: with Gerry occupied, only one other person would have the confidence to sit down at his table unannounced.

"Good afternoon, Ms. Pips." Nicholas's eyes still tracked movement on the floor, specifically the movements of a black-haired waitress whose chest was precariously close to spilling out of her blouse.

"Good afternoon yourself, Angel."

"You know I abhor that nickname." At last he turned to face her, a slender woman whose face was surprisingly free of her years. She wore a pantsuit and her hair back as usual, and today she had added just a touch of makeup. People often had a fearful image of Ms. Pips based on her reputation; they rarely expected her to look so pleasant or speak so gently. Of course, after meeting her they also didn't expect her cold-blooded tactics or policies of swift vengeance either, so in a way they were deceived both coming and going.

"Then you shouldn't go so far out of your way to earn it," Ms. Pips replied. "It seems the Angel of the Cards dealt Nathaniel quite a trouncing in poker the other night." A waiter approached their table nervously and set down a glass of white wine. Ms. Pips rarely rested even long enough to sit; when she did there was a standing order for any service staff to have wine in front of her immediately. She nodded her acknowledgement to the waiter, who fled as soon as her piercing eyes were off of him.

"Nathaniel Evers is the same one-trick pony he was four years ago. I'll

admit the glowing orange eyes and creepy demeanor accentuate his power, but I'd hoped by now he would have extended his repertoire a bit."

"The ability to see people's fears is still enough to unnerve most players."

"Please; my fears are the very least of my daily concerns. He's welcome to them, just so long as I'm welcome to his chips."

"You took quite a few of them, if reports are accurate."

Nicholas reached across the table and took a healthy sip of his own wine. "They were."

"Glad to hear it. Since you performed so well, I went ahead and got you a little Christmas present," Ms. Pips said, flashing a smile that seemed too small to show so many gleaming teeth.

"Oh?"

"If you take the time to tour the casino today, you'll find it staffed with every single new female hire I've made in the time since you left for school," Ms. Pips explained.

Nicholas had indeed noticed a few fresh faces treading across the floor below, but he hadn't yet noted the extensive lack of familiar ones. He cast his eyes back down to the casino and allowed a smile of his own to bloom across his face.

"Now I feel bad. I didn't get you anything."

"You crushed and humiliated that Evers boy in front of everyone," Ms. Pips reminded him.

"Yes, but I took pleasure in that."

"Not nearly as much as I did." Ms. Pips finished her glass of wine and rose from the table. "I've got to get back to work. Do try to use a little self-restraint today. You've still got two weeks here and you can be a bit boorish when you run out of new distractions."

"I'll pace myself."

Ms. Pips left it at that and turned back to her own matters. The boy would do as he wished; that was prerogative of those who served the family well. She was sure he'd go through more than was prudent; he was always so

energetic on his first few weeks back home. Truthfully, Ms. Pips was impressed he'd managed to quell his appetite enough to stay in character while off at college. That was her nephew for you; just when you thought you'd found a weak point in his defenses, you discovered he'd refortified it years ago.

\* \* \*

Mary sat in the thick heat of her trailer as a thin dusting of snow fell across her forest. She'd spent some time with her parents, but today the rest of the extended family was over. Though Mary could stop the influx of thoughts now, she hadn't possessed that talent when she was younger. As a result she'd heard how they felt about her when she was growing up. There was something disconcerting for a child to see a smiling face offering presents and yet to hear them pitying her poor parents for having birthed such a freak. Mary didn't spend time around them now; she hadn't since she left home.

She sat in the streaming sunlight of a window with her bear perched on her lap. She'd waffled between reading a book and doing some of the practice techniques Professor Stone had taught her. In the end she'd settled on the book, if for no other reason than she felt the holiday entitled her to at least one day of laziness.

Dimly she was beginning to grow aware that she was a bit bored out here. Before Lander the silence had been paradise, but after a year and a half of living at Melbrook, plus a summer with Alice, Mary suspected she'd grown used to the sound of perpetual chaos. In a small part of her heart this saddened her: quiet had always been her refuge and she loathed to see it lose that quality. Most of her was happy with the discovery, after some time to mull it over. Mary had spent her whole life watching people find happiness by being around one another, a feat she had envied but never been able to replicate. Now, all this time later, she'd gone and gained the ability herself without even noticing it.

If there were any better Christmas present in all the world, Mary couldn't have told you what it was.

## 91.

“Uncle!” A dark-haired young sprite of a girl came racing down the driveway, pigtails bouncing behind her with every over-enthusiastic step. Mr. Numbers didn’t even break his pace; he swept the girl into his arms with one fluid motion and gave her a solid squeeze. She hugged him back, gripping his strong neck for all she was worth.

“Hey there, Carmen. How’s my favorite niece doing?”

“I’m your only niece!”

“That’s why you’re my favorite.”

The front door Carmen had burst out of remained open; a woman only a year or two younger than Mr. Numbers stood just inside of it. She smiled as he made his way up the driveway, giving him a much gentler embrace designed to show affection without crushing her daughter.

“Glad you could make it, Luke.”

“Come on, Sara. You know I never miss a Christmas when I can help it.” He set the small girl down with some effort then reached into the small suitcase he’d kept gripped in his free hand. “Now then, can someone tell me where the presents go?”

“You can put them under the tree!” Carmen squealed excitedly. “You can’t miss it, the lights are using a new filament I designed that makes them three times brighter!”

“Three times brighter? That is very impressive.”

“Carmen, before we show your uncle the tree, you need to go wash up. We’re going to have lunch soon.”

“Awwwwwwwww.”

“Don’t ‘aw’ me, young lady. Clean hands at the table,” Sara reiterated.

“Fiiiine,” Carmen yielded. She sprinted up the stairs to her bathroom, where she would be torn between her inclination to dawdle and her desire to see her uncle.

“That will give us a few minutes,” Sara said once the child-shaped

cache of energy had left the room. “Let’s get you settled.” The two walked briskly down the hallway, their shared heritage evident in the way they moved and the general shape of their bodies. Sara opened a door on the right of the hall and ushered her slightly-older brother through it. He set his bag on the bed, but only after removing a few crayon drawings that already littered the top of the comforter.

“So, how is she doing?” Mr. Numbers flipped through the papers, admiring his niece’s handiwork. She wasn’t much of an artist, but he did like the sketch of a pony jumping over a differential equation.

“Better,” Sara replied, moving some clothes she’d meant to put away before he arrived. “It’s still hard on her with her father on the road for work so much. I think she’s less lonely since she got into her new courses. Some of the tenured professors there are able to speak on her level, which seems to make her feel a lot more included.”

Mr. Numbers folded the drawing and slid it into the breast pocket of his jacket. “She’s doing better than I did at her age.”

“That’s not a terribly high bar to make it over,” Sara said with a sly look. From anyone else it would have been an insult; from his sister it was endearing sass.

“Granted. Has she had any luck making friends her own age?”

“Not really. She gets along fine when they’re talking about cartoons and games, but sooner or later she’ll reference the gravitational equation during a round of jump rope and then she’s back on the outside.”

“I’ll talk to her. If nothing else I can take her to an ice show or something while I’m here. Carmen deserves to be a kid.”

“She’ll love that.” Sara hesitated a moment, then continued. “You know, Luke, when we were kids I always thought you were full of it every time you talked about how hard it was to be different.”

“You thought I was just being a whiner.”

“I did. I couldn’t fathom how having a brain like yours was anything but a blessing. Now, raising Carmen and seeing her always trying so hard to find a place where she belongs, I get what you meant. I’m sorry I wasn’t a little more understanding back then.”

“Sara, it was absurd for me to expect you to understand. You had no



frame of reference, no way to comprehend what I was talking about,” Mr. Numbers reassured her. “I’m just glad Carmen at least has a mother who can make her feel loved and accepted. Hopefully that will keep her from ending up like me.”

“Oh yes, heaven forbid she end up like her uncle, the wildly successful corporate accounts analyst,” Sara said. “Come on, let’s go put your presents under the tree. You and I both know if Carmen so much as hears them slide in the box she’ll deduce what’s inside.”

Mr. Numbers pulled several brightly colored boxes from his suitcase and followed his sister back down the hallway.

\* \* \*

There was a thick layer of snow on top of the steel roof that protected the seemingly abandoned concrete building. Occasionally a sheet of frosty white precipitation would slide onto the ground with a muffled thump. Had there been any passers-by, they might have assumed the interior to be waterlogged and decrepit. They would have, at the very best, presumed it to be cold and barren as the chill soaked through the concrete walls. They would certainly never have imagined that Christmas lights glowed along the doorways or that the pleasant smell of cooking turkey permeated through its halls.

Persephone was in a small room that had once been an office when this place had been functional. Now they’d stuffed it with free weights and a boxing bag to create a makeshift gym. It wasn’t much compared to the facilities she’d left behind, but it served its purpose. A series of quick blows to the bag made echoing thuds throughout the room. Persephone loved that sound; it brought a multitude of memories flooding back every time.

“You should clean up. We’re going to eat soon.” Persephone didn’t have to turn; she knew His voice by heart. She turned anyway. He stood in the open doorway, sporting the usual unflappable smile. A few flakes of snow trickled out of His hair, remnants of His trip earlier in the day.

“I’m fine. I’ll eat when I finish up.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. It’s Christmas, this is a time for being with family.”

“None of us are related,” Persephone quipped, turning her attention back to the bag.

“You say that like it matters.”

“Of course it matters. Isn’t that the basis of family?” Persephone could feel Him looking at her without turning her head. No, it was worse than that; she could feel Him looking through her. A gentle hand settled on her shoulder and it was all she could do not show any reaction.

“Blood means nothing more than similar genetic markers,” He said, His voice both firm and calming at once. “Family is who you care about, and I can assure every person at that table cares a great deal about you.”

Persephone closed her eyes. She could have called bullshit on anyone else for dropping a line like that, but not Him. It wasn’t just that He genuinely believed it, it wasn’t even that He made other people around Him desire to believe it. It was that He made it true. He didn’t merely see the world the way He wanted it to be, He actually changed the world by moving through it. All of His power, and it was still this mundane yet impossible ability that mesmerized Persephone more than any other. It was why she’d chosen Him to believe in after her... incident, it was why she’d thrown away her entire career to help Him.

“Geez, you’re corny,” she said, eyes still firmly shut. “Let me shower and I’ll come join you guys.”

“We’ll wait for you,” He assured her, releasing her shoulder with one last comforting squeeze.

## 92.

The dawn of the spring semester is generally a cheerful occasion, regardless of the individual campus one analyzes. Though the prospect of returning to classes looms just over the horizon, there is the promise of new friends and lovers that will be met over the coming months. There is also the joy of re-joining with friends that were scattered to the winds in their own treks home. It is this unique combination of new and old that manages to overpower even the crushing ennui of facing more tests and papers. Of course, there are exceptions to every rule, and not every reunion is a welcome one.

Alex was halfway to his floor when he sensed a very familiar mind. It was three floors up and several doors over, but the minute he touched it he knew who it belonged to. Alex contemplated turning around and going back to his car. He had very little stowed away in the trunk, and nothing that was perishable. A few hours out of the air-conditioning wouldn't do any lasting harm.

Ultimately he decided against it and resumed his upward journey. He might have gone for the run if he hadn't felt the steely determination in the mind that was waiting for him. She wasn't going to leave. She knew he could sense her before she saw his face and she was determined to wait right where she was until he gave in and went to his room. Alex knew damned well that once she was set on something there was no turning her around. Besides, better to get this out of the way as soon as possible.

Alex stepped out of the stairwell and shifted the box he was holding. It wasn't particularly heavy, not to someone with frequent physical conditioning at least, but he felt compelled to do something with his hands and the box was the most convenient item to fiddle with. She was sitting in front of his door, looking down the hall at him. As he drew closer, she pulled herself to a standing position.

"Hey," Selena said softly.

"Why are you here?" Alex's tone was harsher than he might have chosen under different circumstances; however, this was an occasion where a gentle approach would only do more harm than good.

"I was hoping we could talk. I tried to call you over the break."

“I know. I ignored the calls.” Alex brushed past her and unlocked his door. He struggled with a moment of internal debate as he twisted the knob: should he keep Selena in the hall or let her in? If he let her in then things could take the wrong turn and get complicated, but if they stayed in the hall the neighbors who were returning would see far more of his personal life than Alex was comfortable with. He walked in and set his box down, leaving the door open behind him. Selena could make her own decision on what was best for the conversation.

There was a click as Selena shut the door. Alex sat down in his computer desk chair and swiveled around to face her. The bed would have been more comfortable; but it also would have been vastly more dangerous.

“I wanted to tell you that I’m sorry,” Selena said, shifting in place. She didn’t make any motion to sit. This wasn’t supposed to be comfortable for her; she understood that much already.

“You’ve already said that, multiple times,” Alex reminded her. “I understand that you’re sorry. I’ll probably even be able to forgive you one day, once I’ve gotten some distance from all of this.”

“Alex, it was a mistake and I know it. I came to you after it happened and told you everything. Please, I really like you. I don’t want things to end like this.”

“That might have been something to keep in mind before you fucked Allen at Thomas’s party.”

Selena didn’t draw back at the crude comment, she merely nodded her head. Later, many hours and miles from this moment, she would sob muffled tears in the dark of her room. It wouldn’t be because of his harsh words, or because he reminded her of her sin. It would be because she’d done something so horrible that the gentlest boy she’d ever met could act that viciously towards her.

“It was a mistake,” Selena repeated. “I was drunk, and you weren’t there, and...”

“And you cheated on me,” Alex finished for her. “We’ve had this fight, like, five times now, Selena. I know you feel bad about it, I really do, but I don’t want to be with someone I can’t trust.”

“You can trust me! I told you everything that happened the very next day!” Selena’s voice was rising; she was losing her calm demeanor. Alex felt

a rising urge to comfort her. His instincts hadn't gotten the memo that the girl he'd spent nearly a year nuzzling was now no longer to even be touched. He needed to end this before desire and love overcame basic reasoning.

"I'll admit, you did tell me the very next day," Alex agreed, rising from his chair. "But I have to wonder, was that because you couldn't bear to lie to me, or because you knew it would only be a matter of time before I sensed all the guilt leaking out of you and decided to dig deeper?" His eyes bore into her almond-colored irises. He wasn't looking for any twitches or glances: he didn't need such tricks to know the truth. He simply wanted to look into those eyes one last time before he banished them from his life.

"I didn't want to lie to you," Selena said forcefully. Her tone was even, her body language secure. Alex could have believed her; hell, he wanted to believe her. It would have given them some place to work from, shaky and unstable but not impossible to fortify. It would have been hope. Alex didn't believe her, because he could sense the worms of doubt wriggling through her mind. She didn't really know for certain whether she would have come clean had her boyfriend not been telepathic. It was understandable; that kind of moral dilemma is tested in the doing, not in speculation. However, the fact remained that she didn't know what she would have done, which meant Alex knew what he had to do. Relationships were built on trust, trust that he simply no longer possessed.

"I don't believe you," Alex said. There was no anger in his voice, no fierceness, only a cold sense of detachment. "I don't trust you. Right now, I don't even like you. It's over. One day maybe we can be civil to one another, but we are never going to be together again."

"But—"

"Never. Stop calling me. Stop dropping by my dorm. Don't even talk to me. There is nothing left between us. Now get out."

Selena stared at him for a moment, her mouth opening once but closing before any sound escaped. She turned and walked over to the door, pulling it open slowly, as if waiting for him to stop her from walking out. He didn't. It was only willpower and pride that kept her from taking one last glance back as she left the room and walked carefully down the hallway.

To his own credit, it was nearly a full minute after the door closed before Alex's first tears began to fall.

## 93.

The first few days of classes were largely unremarkable. Syllabi were handed out, new classrooms scanned and assessed for hook-up possibilities, and stomachs were forced to readjust to dorm food after several weeks of home-cooked goodness. Below the lush grass of Lander's campus, a relatively small percentage of the total student population were dealing with stiff bodies and sore muscles as they got back into their training regimens. The smarter ones had kept up with at least a semblance of practice during the break, but even they needed an extra-long soak in the hot tub by the time the first week was drawing to a close. Within this sum of time that was, as previously mentioned, largely unremarkable, there were two quite remarkable events that occurred.

The first was a familiar posting of paper that was found by the gym on the sophomores' first day back. It read: "March 1st. Team 1 vs. Team 2. Team 3 vs. Team 4." It was gone the next day, as expected; however, like a tanker ramming through a dock, even once the cause was no longer visible the aftermath was abundantly evident. Efforts redoubled, training increased, and stress bubbled up in even the most stoic of students.

The second event was a two-person meeting that occurred in the classroom assigned to Professor Pendleton, in which a student turned in his extra-credit assignment.

"I have to hand it you," Nick said as he sauntered in five minutes late for their appointment. "That actually proved to be a bit of a challenge."

"Glad to hear that uncovering information that has the highest level of classification was 'a bit' of a challenge," Professor Pendleton replied snidely. The truth was he was a little impressed the kid had actually pulled it off, or at least thought he had. Even for someone like Nick it should have been almost impossible to access that information.

"What can I say? I've got a gift."

"That remains to be seen. So, what is your theory?"

"No foreplay or monologue, just right to the main event, huh? Fine, Blake Hill, in what has to be the least innovative naming convention of all time, worked as a Hero under the moniker Black Hole," Nick said with a dramatic drop into the nearest seat. He'd planned much more theatricality for

the reveal, but Professor Pendleton had taken all the style out of it.

“Nicely done,” Professor Pendleton complimented. “You pass.”

“Goody gumdrops.” Nick took a moment to stretch out in the desk, sprawling across it more effectively than one might have thought logistically possible. “I thought it was a little funny, finding out he was Black Hole. It sounded familiar, and then I remembered that was one of the people on the Hero team with Globe, Intra, and The Alchemist.”

“Most of the professors here had illustrious careers before settling into a teaching role.” Professor Pendleton could have said all instead of most if he and Professor Fletcher weren’t on the staff.

“I’m certain they did. I’m guessing all of them weren’t on an infamous team with Alice’s father.” Nick’s teeth became visible beneath a wicked grin. He might have gotten robbed of one of his reveals, but he had a feeling he’d get to enjoy the next one.

“You know about that?”

“Alice told me last year, back when we were doing a project on Globe. Strange, given how much time they spend together on her training that Professor Hill has never once mentioned his long friendship with her dad.”

“We keep a distance between ourselves and the students. We have to be objective to be able to teach you effectively,” Professor Pendleton replied.

“Some of you do, I’ll grant you that. Still, it seemed like the kind of thing that might have come up in conversation, even casually. There were reasons why it might not, like if Professor Hill wasn’t sure that Alice knew about her father’s Hero exploits. Then I remembered something else from last year. A tidbit of info I picked up when I made a scrapbook for Alice of her mother.” Nick’s sprawl had become compact as he spoke and he drew himself tall into a position of authority.

“That would be?”

“Her mother’s last name, or rather, her maiden name. If I recall correctly, which I always do, it was Hill.”

“Hill is a common last name,” Professor Pendleton rebutted.

“Sixteenth most common in America. It was still enough to make me dig deeper. Funny thing, county birth records aren’t nearly as secure as you’d

think.”

“I do have other appointments today; can we cut to the chase?”

“Professor Hill is Alice’s uncle,” Nick said simply, a bit of his posture slumping. The professor just kept pilfering the wind from his sails today.

“Is he? I hadn’t expected that. I’m sure you can see why he’s remained quiet on the subject, then. Professor Hill is a professional and he wouldn’t want to raise the question of if he is giving his niece special treatment.”

“Makes total sense,” Nick agreed, slowly pulling himself out of his desk. “What makes significantly less sense is why Alice didn’t already know that. I mean, she was a Powered her whole life, it isn’t as if Professor Hill could have anticipated she’d go to Lander.”

“It is a sad truth that not every member of every family gets along. Perhaps Professor Hill and Alice’s father are not on amiable enough terms for him to see his niece.”

“Maybe. But it seems sort of funny that two people who served on a team together would be that distant from one another.”

“That was decades ago. People and friendships can change tremendously in that amount of time.”

“I suppose it’s possible,” Nick acquiesced. “Anyway, it’s none of my business; I got what you asked me for.”

“That you did,” Professor Pendleton agreed. “As I said, you pass.”

“Glad to hear it.” With that, Nick threw his backpack over his shoulder and sauntered out of the room, on to his next class and deception.

As Nick exited a small grin grew across Professor Pendleton’s face. It bloomed into the kind of smile that was often described as a ‘cat that got the canary’ smirk. It had been a while since Professor Pendleton had seen a plan come together so well; he’d almost forgotten about the tingle that flowed through his fingers or the light euphoria that danced in his brain.

“By the by,” Nick said, sticking his head back through the door. “I figured all that out in the first two days of break. By the fifth day I’d realized from the coincidences that you set me up to draw Professor Hill precisely so I would uncover all that information. They were all things you wanted me to know but couldn’t tell me. So I went back and did some more extensive



research. It was so extensive, in fact, that I discovered the thing you were hoping I wouldn't find. Just wanted to let you know. Toodles."

With that Nick was gone, leaving only a very flustered professor whose grin had vanished like a ninja in smoke.

## 94.

Vince stepped out of the men's locker room to find that he was surrounded. Stella stood directly before him, a vantage point which he would later reflect had to offer some views of what transpired inside, Violet to his right and a somewhat uncomfortable looking Thomas was at his left. The girls had very serious looks of sternness on their faces, while Thomas more looked like he might have had a disagreeable meal that was only now making its presence known.

"Um, hey, guys. What's up?"

"Not much," Stella said in a tone that made it quite clear that much was indeed up. "How about you? Having a nice day? Any big plans for the weekend?"

"It was good so far," Vince replied hesitantly. "I'll probably just do the usual this weekend. Train and study and maybe catch a movie."

"Mmmmmhmmmmmm." Violet made the sound somewhere in the middle of her throat, allowing it to sound both casual and disapproving. "I told you so, Stella."

"Now, Violet, we agreed to give him a chance," Stella said, moving only her eyes. Those glaring orbs soon turned back to Vince, unfortunately. "So that's all? Training, studying, and maybe a movie? You're sure there's not anything else on your schedule for this weekend? Nothing of significant importance that may have slipped your mind just now?"

"Pretty sure." Vince found his body sliding itself into a defensive stance, even though he wasn't certain why.

"Typical," Violet sighed. "Even the nice ones are as considerate as rocks."

"I'm really confused," Vince admitted.

"One of your teammates has a birthday this weekend," Stella explained. "We were hoping you'd taken the time to at least put something together."

"I don't think so," Vince disagreed. "Hershel and Nick both have theirs in summer, Mary's is over Christmas break, and Alice's isn't for

another few months.”

“Typical,” Violet repeated.

Stella jabbed a surprisingly bony finger into Vince’s sternum. “Camille. You know, the small one who could have been on a top tier team but instead decided to help you guys out? The sweet one who goes to every practice, ignoring the fact that she has her skills down pat, because she wants to show team spirit? The girl who encouraged all of us to support you people after your little revelation, and who evidently you don’t think of as a teammate just because she isn’t in the guinea pig club?”

“Oh.”

“‘Oh’ is fucking right,” Stella agreed.

“But she never told any of us when her birthday was,” Vince defended lamely.

“She never tells anyone,” Violet countered. “She doesn’t do anything to draw attention to herself. You’ve worked with her for a half a year and you didn’t notice that? We found out by invading her privacy and prying into her life, just like good friends should.”

Vince glanced at Thomas, hoping for support. Thomas squirmed in place as a response. Had it been a villain or a monster of any caliber, Thomas would happily have stood at his friend’s side and faced the impossible odds in battle. Against these two... even bravery has its limits.

Stella, meanwhile, was rearing for another assault. “And another thing-”

“You’re right,” Vince interrupted, his eyes falling from Thomas to the floor.

The proverbial wind seemed to slip a bit from Stella’s sails. “What was that?”

“I said you’re right. Camille is always so supportive of everyone, and we just took her for granted. It didn’t even occur to me to figure out when her birthday was, but I should have. Just because she didn’t used to be Powered doesn’t mean she isn’t one of us. It was inconsiderate and selfish.”

“Well, at least this one can admit when it’s wrong,” Violet said.

Stella’s glare was still quite imposing, but she lowered her finger and

Vince's chest relaxed accordingly. "Make sure you don't let it happen again. We love that girl, and we hate to see her go unappreciated."

"I won't," Vince promised. Stella saw something in his eyes at that moment, a piece of the greater whole that was Vince Reynolds. She was not one to take people at their word, but in that instant, she had a feeling that when Vince made a promise even the gods counted it as done.

"Good," Stella said. "Now, since this isn't about shaming you as much as it is about making Camille feel good, we went ahead and put something together. You're going to invite her to a birthday dinner at the Karaoke Barn on Saturday night. We'll spread the word around to other students after you've told her."

"I don't know if it is right for me to take credit for the plans you organized."

"What do you think would mean more to Camille, finding out we threw her another party or finding out the team she's been working with thought so much of her that they beat us to it?" Violet asked. She couldn't say the other part, the piece about how it really mattered that Vince was the one who invited her. Last year the small girl had tried every trick in the book to weasel out of her own event. If it was something put together for her especially by Vince, on the other hand, Violet had a feeling not even the apocalypse wouldn't keep her away.

"Then shouldn't the captain be the one to invite her?" Vince asked.

Stella and Violet glanced at each other. That was a good point, and one they hadn't thought of. It was Thomas who came to their aid, accidentally justifying their decision to drag him along.

"The captain isn't the one who organizes the fun; the captain is the one who leads the team. Goof-off events should really come from someone else, if only for the sake of appearances."

"I guess that makes sense; usually Nick is the one who recommends all the things we do to waste time," Vince agreed.

"Glad you're on board," Stella said, retaking control of the conversation. "Karaoke Barn, Saturday night at seven. I expect to get a panicked call from her by tonight or so help me our next visit won't be so pleasant." Stella turned on her heel and began walking away, Violet only a few steps behind.

Thomas paused a moment before following. “They really do mean well.”

“I’m sure they do. Still not positive why my heart is beating so fast,” Vince noted.

“Just be glad they like you enough to take it easy. I’ve seen them come down hard on people and it’s not a pretty sight.” Thomas jogged off to catch up with the girls, leaving a stunned Vince by himself to recover.

## 95.

“Mr. Murray, am I boring you?”

Will swiveled his head toward the chemistry professor, who was glaring at him as snickers of his classmates filled the room. “No, sir.”

“Then why have you not looked at your book once in last ten minutes?”

It was true; Will confirmed it with a dart of his eyes to the clock. He’d let his mind wander to more essential tasks and his focus had gotten away from him. The truth was Will’s attendance to this class was purely out of courtesy in the first place. He was already well-acquainted with every concept that would be covered and could likely teach the professor a few lessons on the subject matter. That was the HCP side of Will, however; up here he had to pass for a normal student, he had to be like everyone else.

“I’m sorry, sir.”

“It’s your education, Mr. Murray. I can’t force you to take it seriously; but, if you don’t fix your attitude, I’m sure the results will be apparent by the end of this course.”

“I’ll do better, sir.”

“That remains to be seen.”

The professor began to lecture again, and Will made a point of staring at his book as his concentration ebbed away. He couldn’t help it; this morning he’d seen Jill field a call from Glenn during a class. It wasn’t surprising that he called when he knew she couldn’t answer, or that she almost picked up the phone anyway. No, the worrying part was that when she’d glanced at the phone Will saw The Look on her face. It was a mixture of uncertainty, worry, and just a trace of fear. It meant that the Glenn situation had progressed to the point where Jill faced repercussions for something as simple as an unanswered call. It had been a long time since Will saw The Look on his sister’s face, and he’d hoped with all he had to never see it again.

\* \* \*

Snow had fallen two days ago, but the streets downtown didn’t tolerate such pleasantries for long. Heat from passing cars had turned the

white powder into a grey slush that ran in dark rivers down the drains positioned at key points along the corners. It was not a scene appropriate to any holiday, let alone Christmas, but people who moved here didn't do it in search of picturesque nostalgia. One mound of dirty slush bore a small footprint, made by a boy no more than ten years old. This was discernible not by an exceptional means of deduction, but rather by the fact that the boy in question stood only a few feet away from his inadvertent mark.

He was a lean boy, bearing the figure of one who is either in the middle of or just completing a growth spurt. The store window he stood in front of was dark, but the light from the streetlamps reflected off of his thick glasses housed in quite unfashionable frames. His gaze was unwavering from the storefront set before him; even as the wind tugged at his too-thin jacket, the boy's focus never slipped. Neither did the brick clutched tightly in his hand.

Will Murray, never Billy or Bill or even the proper William, for those names lacked a very specific characteristic, took mental inventory of the poorly-lit hardware store from his stance on the street. Power saws, sanders, chainsaws, the place had an ample supply of base mechanical parts. It also held a section for computer hardware; the owners had felt that offering both types of product would widen their demographic and hopefully double their business. What they had learned instead was that the people who work on computers and the people who work with industrial tools are very rarely comfortable around one another. It was why they hadn't gotten a store in a better part of town, it was why their alarm system had been cheap and taken no time to disengage, and it was why Will had chosen this store out of all the others he knew about.

His arm was getting tired. Will was hesitating and he knew it. This was the last place where he could still walk away from everything. Hurling the brick would quite literally be the point of no return. He'd have to push forward, no matter what happened. Will was a very smart child; he knew that the odds dictated almost exclusively negative endings following this course of action. Even if he succeeded, this was a serious crime. With a criminal history on his resume it would be almost impossible to get into the Hero Certification Program one day, to say nothing of the time he'd spend in juvenile hall. It had been his dream for so long, and now that they were finally willing to call what he had a certifiable power, he was going to shatter that dream right along with this storefront window.

Jill would call him stupid. Jill would say he should think about the

future, not be so impulsive. Jill wasn't here; their mother had won custody of her in the divorce. Jill would say she was fine, she would say they were only little bruises and their mother so rarely lost control to that point. Jill didn't understand patterns of escalation. Jill couldn't fathom the depths of their mother's instability. Jill refused to acknowledge that her injuries were getting bigger and showing up more frequently. Will saw all of it; he saw what had come to pass and what lurked on the horizon. Will had seen The Look in his sister's face when their mother picked her up today. Will understood it was only a matter of time before Jill became hurt in a way that could never be repaired.

The glass made a tinkling sound as it rained to the ground. Will had expected something louder, more ear-catching. He supposed that was due to the exaggerations of cinema and their over-the-top sound effects. Will was surprised to realize he felt calmer than he had before the throw. Perhaps it was because there was no longer anything to fret over. The die, or in this case brick, had been cast. The ramifications were upon him regardless of how he proceeded from here. Knowing that, it was clear that the logical choice was to do his very best to save Jill before the repercussions caught up to him.

The boy stepped carefully over the jagged shards of his dream and the storefront glass. It was a shame; he had genuinely wanted to be a Hero someday. The idea was pleasant, but ultimately irrelevant. No Hero was going to help Jill, no cape-wearing champion would steal her away from the house where she regularly cowered in fear. Only her brother, only Will, would be the one to save her. There was a soft click as Will turned on his flashlight, a dim beam of light slicing through the dark interior. The time for reflection was done; now was the time for action.

Will Murray, the only moniker he accepted of all the nickname options because it appropriately rhymed with his sister's, pulled off his mitten and began to work.



“Most of you did quite well on your emotional recognition assignment,” Professor Pendleton said, handing back stacks of photos that each student had been tasked with assessing. Some of the faces were enthusiastic in their expression, while others were little more than deadpan. Each had to be plumbed for their contents; seeing what existed beneath the surface was a key aspect for anyone in the Subtlety field, especially in regards to reading people.

“Of course, there were some students who showed significantly less competence.” Alice’s paper was dropped dramatically on her desk, just in case anyone had been wondering who the professor was referring to. She bit her lip to hold back the flush of shame that was trying to mar her normally perfect skin. This was a technique Nick had taught her; pain took higher precedence in the brain’s hierarchy than embarrassment so it reacted to the injury instead of humiliation.

Alice hadn’t expected to ace the assignment: while she had practice reading people, her skill depended on things like tone and inflection more than just facial composition. She had at least hoped not to embarrass herself. At this point she just wanted to get through to the end of the year when Subtlety would undoubtedly be dropped from her schedule. Sadly, it looked as though she had a long way to go before she reached that finish line.

“I thought this week we’d do something a little more active than our usual analysis work,” Professor Pendleton announced after dropping the last stack of papers with its owner. “You all are going to be learning the art of tailing.”

The class looked at him with piqued interest. Most students would know the term, but likely wouldn’t be excited by the subject matter. Professor Pendleton’s class didn’t contain “most students.” These were the ones who adored the topics he covered and hungered for practice as they grew bloated with theory. Tailing would provide that; there was no way to master it without a fair bit of actual doing.

“This will be a game called Watching and Spotting, the goal of which is to achieve five points by this time next week. The Watching part of your assignment will be to follow someone from this class for a span of three hours without being noticed. You must document their activities carefully, as this

will be the proof that you succeeded. Completing this task will earn you one point.” Professor Pendleton stepped across the room, forcing their eyes to follow. He was keenly proud of this exercise and he wanted to make certain they paid full attention for the explanation of it.

“Conversely, Spotting occurs if you should find yourself being followed. You may document the timeframe during which you see your pursuer and turn it in for one point. This will, of course, negate the Watcher’s point.”

“Wait, so if we watch someone without getting spotted we get a point, but if they see us then they’re the one to actually get a point?” Alice asked.

“Correct,” Professor Pendleton confirmed. “A timeframe and activity log must be presented along with the notice of a Spot. It will be compared to the notes the Watcher submits, and if the Spot does not match at least one hour out of the three of pursuit, then the Spot will not be counted.”

This time it was Julia who interrupted the professor. “You’re saying when we watch someone, we don’t know if they spot us or not. That comes out when everyone turns their stuff in. So if we don’t know if we were caught then how do we know if we have enough points to pass?”

“You don’t.”

“Oh.” Julia looked visibly disturbed.

“If you can’t tell whether the person you are Watching is aware of your existence then you don’t truly deserve the points,” Professor Pendleton explained. “All information gathering is an active process. You can’t just observe, you need to know if the person is aware you are observing. If they are then they could feed you false information. By the same logic, if you know that they know then you can twist the tables on them.”

“I’m confused,” Gilbert moaned from the back.

“He’s saying that a Watcher can screw a Spotter right back. Think about it: a Spot only counts if you successfully identified your Watcher and the time frame you submit consists of at least one of the three hours you were being Watched. If the Watcher realizes they’ve been seen, they can always elect not to turn in their notes on that tail, thereby depriving the Spotter of their point.” Tiffani Hunt drew many curious glances with her outburst, but the nod of approval from Professor Pendleton told her she was on the money.

“Well said. Identifying misinformation is even more important than obtaining information in the first place,” Professor Pendleton continued. “Now that we’ve covered how the game works, or at least as much as I’m willing to explain it, I’ll briefly touch on grading. Five points is the goal so it is an A. Four is a B, three a C, two a D, and anyone with one point or less will receive a failing grade.” A familiar hand shot up from the center of the desks and Professor Pendleton resisted the urge to sigh loudly. “Ms. Adair, I am not going to go back over how-”

“What if we get more than five points?” Alice felt a twinge of shame interrupting a teacher, but she wasn’t going to let a golden opportunity slip by.

“More than five points?”

“Yes. What if we exceed the goal?”

Professor Pendleton stared at her for a long moment, the wheels in his head turning so loudly some of the students near the front could make out a faint ‘click-clack’ noise. “If, and that is a mighty big if, you are able to get over five points, then you will receive bonus credit. Each point over will raise a previous assignment by one letter grade, at a maximum of ten.”

“And what if-”

“If you exceed ten then you have hopelessly too much time on your hands,” Professor Pendleton said, this time cutting her off. “But I’ll concede the possibility. Anyone who exceeds ten points will be invited to a special challenge session. Should someone come away from that session victorious they will have an automatic A on the final exam for this class.”

The class buzzed; HCP course finals were notoriously difficult. Jumping through all those hoops had to be an afternoon on the couch by comparison. Many students set their will to accomplish the impossible, despite the fact that less than a minute before they’d been wondering how they would ever pull a passing grade out of this assignment. Amidst it all, Professor Pendleton wondered about the curiosity of the fact that Alice, one of the class’s worst performers, was sitting at her desk with a smug smile across her face.

“This wardrobe is wasted on you,” Nick said as he sifted through Vince’s closet. The bulk of the former wanderer’s clothes had been provided for him along with his dorm furnishings and monthly allotment. It was part of the “scholarship” that their program provided, along with tuition and class fees. The others hadn’t been provided with quite as much as Vince; then again, they hadn’t needed nearly as much, either. Nick had always thought of it as a form of payment for letting themselves become human guinea pigs, but given that the experiment had worked, he supposed the blood money arrangement worked out in their favor.

“Over half this stuff still has tags on it.” A tumble of clothes fell upon Vince’s bed as Nick cleared the way to view more options.

“I’ve never had many clothes. I just find what’s comfortable and keep wearing it,” Vince replied from his desk. He was doing some homework before heading off to Camille’s birthday event, determined not to find himself in the same kind of situation as he had last semester.

“That’s very Zen of you, but adding variety to one’s rotational ensemble isn’t always a bad thing. For instance, you might already know what to wear tonight instead of having me help you.”

“I’m sorry. I didn’t expect it to be formal.”

“Funny how that works. You’re the one who put together Camille’s shindig yet you didn’t realize Karaoke Barn has a strict dress code.” Nick didn’t bother giving Vince the accusing glare. He’d no more believed his friend had organized this event than he believed Bigfoot was secretly in charge of The Masons.

“It’s called Karaoke Barn! Why would I expect that to require suits and dresses?”

“The name is ironic; it’s one of the swankier places in town. Private rooms, highbrow food, I hear they do a non-complimentary valet even though there’s tons of parking available.” Nick knew, of course, that the relevance of that last fact would be lost on someone like Vince. Really the only person in Melbrook who might have fathomed its significance was Alice, and Nick had already found himself a bit too fond of her company lately. He needed to put a little space between himself and his blonde teammate.

“I know that, now.” ‘Now’ had occurred when Vince showed Nick the jeans and T-shirt he planned to wear that night. It had not gone over well.

“Just be glad we did a pre-screen. It would have been mortifying if you’d shown up in those rags.”

“They aren’t rags.”

“They are compared to what you should be wearing.” Nick pulled back another section of clothes and revealed a piece that demanded he let out a low whistle. “And what you should be wearing, pretty much always, is this.”

Nick plucked free a three-button suit that was still bound in plastic wrap. It was the color of smoke and had clearly been fashioned with Vince in mind. His lean frame had put on a bit of muscle thanks to his HCP conditioning, but Vince would still fit strikingly into this outfit. Nick could already visualize it, and the image made him want to pick something a little nicer than what he’d planned for himself. Nick could deal with many things, but being drab, even if only by comparison, wasn’t one of them.

“Oh yeah, I forgot about that,” Vince said, rising from his desk. “I saw it the first week I was here. Didn’t know where I’d ever wear it to.”

“You knew it was here, yet you let me spend half an hour rooting through the dregs of your closet?”

“I forgot.” Vince shrugged like only the truly innocent and the truly idiotic are capable.

“Of course you did.” Nick thrust the suit to his friend, who accepted it gently. “I’m going to leave while you try it on. Add the accoutrements, too; I’m helping you itemize all afternoon.”

“Accoutrements?”

“Yeah, you know: shoes, belt, rings, watches, all the periphery shit.”

“I don’t think I have that.”

Nick jerked his thumb toward the now ravaged closet. “Go dig. If there’s a suit then there’s at least a matching belt and shoes. As for watches, what about that pocket watch you keep on your bedside table?”

Vince didn’t glance toward where Nick’s eyes were looking; he already knew perfectly well what watch he meant.

“I don’t really wear that out.”

“And with your usual clothes you shouldn’t. With this suit, on the other hand, it would be a welcome addition. Tell you what, get dressed and I’ll show you how to run the chain, then you can decide for yourself.”

“I guess I could do that,” Vince agreed reluctantly.

“Then hurry. Some of us have to get ready too, you know.”

\* \* \*

When a room is thoroughly disheveled the phrase ‘it looks like a bomb went off in there’ is frequently used. This description, while popular, is wildly inaccurate. It ignores the fact that most bombs civilians are familiar with are not designed to create craters; rather they use a controlled amount of explosives to send fragments and shrapnel as projectiles. It also fails to take into account that even if the first condition were not true, such a situation would invariably leave scorch marks as collateral damage to the area in question. So, Camille Belden’s room certainly did not look like a bomb had gone off in it. It did, however, look as if a team of specially trained agents had scoured through it looking for illegal contraband. Unfortunately for Camille, neither of these were the case.

“Try these on next,” Violet demanded, setting a pair of heels Camille was certain she’d never bought onto the bed. Camille didn’t buy heels; she’d never even worn a pair. These must have been included in one of her mother’s care packages. She was always encouraging Camille to dress more lady-like.

“Ooooooh, with the green dress,” Stella chimed in.

“Love it!” Violet agreed cheerfully.

It was a strange thing, Violent Violet and Stella Steel, as they were known in their respective hometowns, setting aside their usual rough demeanors and getting bogged down in the intricacies of hair and makeup. This was not, as some might speculate, because all women are predisposed to such passions regardless of their personality type. It was simply that people are complex creatures, and the joy of burying a fist in someone’s skull does not exclude one from also enjoying the ability to turn heads when walking into a room. Besides, bad as one might assume these girls were at such pageantry, Camille was infinitely worse.

The duo had been at this for hours, fully aware that if they didn’t go

the extra mile to make Camille look irresistible, then she certainly wouldn't do it herself. It was a testament to how much she wanted to go to a party she believed Vince had thrown for her that the small girl was tolerating such abuse. Normally she would have slipped away in some moment of confusion, and she certainly wouldn't have allowed her housemates to wreak such havoc on her normally well-kept room.

"I can't walk in these," Camille said as she turned over the new set of heels in her hand.

"HCP training spends a lot of time on balance, I bet you're better than you think," Stella told her.

"Plus, heels will help close the height distance between you and Vince. The boy is kind of tall," Violet added, resisting the urge to share a conspiratorial wink.

Camille let a sigh die in her chest and began putting on the heels. Denying the truth was as useless as resisting these two. They were relentless, and she was their favorite pet project. At times she wondered why they didn't put as much effort into their own love lives, but it was a question Camille would never ask. Even if they could be annoying at times, she knew that all this effort came from a sincere love for her, so the last thing she wanted to do was say something hurtful. Besides, in the deepest part of her heart, Camille had to admit she wouldn't mind standing even a few inches closer to Vince's lips.

It bears saying that she made it all of ten steps before taking her first tumble, a tally which Stella and Violet mutually agreed had to be a first time heel-wearer record.

## 98.

It was a good thing Karaoke Barn offered private rooms, because the turnout for Camille's party couldn't have easily fit in some obscure corner booth. Her team, along with Thomas and the girls, were there, but also in attendance were some unexpected additions such as Chad, Shane, Britney, Julia, Jill, and Sasha. All of them were trimmed in appropriate apparel, though Julia and Sasha's necklines were treading dangerously close toward defying that definition, and they piled into the large room stocked with several tables and one moderately-sized stage at the center.

People began taking seats where they were available with little consideration of who they were next to. Everyone here was, if not friends, cordial enough to tolerate for the night. Vince noticed he seemed to be herded into the seat next to Camille, one he would have thought her closer friends might have prized. He accepted it with his usual blissfully-ignorant demeanor, turning his attention to the groups of people ambling in as they arrived.

"I thought Will would have come with Thomas," Vince said as he noticed his hyper-intelligent friend was nowhere to be seen.

"Oh, he told us he was going to be late. He had an early evening lab," Camille supplied as she pretended to browse through one of the monolithic song catalogues littering the tables. She would sooner square off against one of the professors in combat to the death than get on the stage to sing; however, the book did make a useful prop for avoiding looking at Vince. The small tolerance she'd grown thanks to working with him all year seemed to have dissipated when she saw him in his suit. The boy cleaned up well.

"Yeesh, I'm glad I don't have to take any science classes."

"You, me, and the entire chemistry department," Nick agreed, pulling out a chair and plopping down at the table. He was dressed closer to Nicholas than Nick, what with his dapper button-down and midnight-black suit. He'd purposely avoided combing his hair too expertly or getting this particular jacket tailored, at least. They were meaningless details unless you were looking for them, and Nick assumed someone was always looking for them.

"I don't think I'd cause too much damage," Vince protested.

"Vince, you're a dear friend, but you screwed up making iced tea," Nick countered.



“He did?” Camille looked up from the songbook.

“He just didn’t know that the machine needed a filter,” Alice defended, making her way over and settling in next to Nick. Her red eye glitter matched the sparkling of her form-fitting red dress that showed just a touch of cleavage. It was beginning to look like this table would be filled only by Team One members, but the last two seats were quickly scooped up by Violet and Stella. Neither of them saw the unhappy look on Sasha’s face, but she had no one but herself to blame for being too slow.

“I’d never used one of those things before; I thought it was built in.”

“Needless to say, the tea was thrown out and we haven’t really let Vince mess around with advanced appliances since,” Nick concluded.

“Too bad. Most girls dig a man who can cook,” Violet pointed out.

“Lord knows I do,” Stella agreed. “I hate that domestic shit, I want to come home and have my meal hot and waiting for me. Maybe with a nice martini on the side.”

“So you want to be a man, in the fifties, in a sitcom?” Nick asked.

“Pretty much.”

Nick turned the idea over in his head a few times. “You know what, I can actually see the appeal there.”

“I am able to cook,” Vince protested, getting his words in at last. “I’m just not good with fancy technological stuff.”

“Items you would find an abundance of in any science lab setting, circling back and proving my original point,” Nick replied.

“So who’s going to sing first?” Violet tossed out, trampling over their repartee.

“My money says it will be whoever is drinking the heaviest,” Alice wagered.

“I don’t know, some people actually enjoy the spotlight and the attention.”

“Oh, if it’s about being an attention whore then Nick will probably be up there before we even order our food,” Alice predicted.

“Funny. Sorry to disappoint, Princess, but not even a river of booze

could get me up there. Being genetically tone-deaf means I can't carry a tune any more than Vince could use the popcorn setting on the microwave."

"I feel like this is getting mean," Vince objected.

"Wait, so the diva of Melbrook has one outlandish activity he won't engage in? No, no, now I've got to hear you sing." Alice plucked one of the books from the table and began rifling through it.

"Flip the pages as fast as you like, there's no way I'm getting up on stage," Nick reaffirmed, turning his attention to a menu rather than a book.

"Oh, come on, do it for Camille. It's her birthday."

"I'm actually okay with people not singing if they don't want to." Camille felt it important to establish this precedent early in case attention was later shifted to her own lack of performance.

"Look, you want me to make an ass of myself, it's going to have to be tit for tat," Nick said.

"I'll go sing," Alice agreed immediately.

"I know you will; we've all heard you belting out top forty hits in the kitchen when you forget you live with other people. That's not a fair exchange, because you wouldn't be embarrassed by singing. You should be, but you wouldn't be."

"No need to be snippy," Alice said with a glare. "Fine, if me singing wouldn't get you up there then how about something equally degrading?"

"I'm listening."

"I'll clean the boys' side bathroom and lounge tomorrow."

Nick raised an eyebrow. "Why exactly would that be a fair trade?"

"Because you always call me Princess, and nothing would cheer your vile little heart more than seeing someone you consider high society doing menial labor." Alice shot him a pointed look with a light smirk underneath. She might not be as good as he was, but she still knew a thing or two about what a man's temptations were.

"I expect a professional-level job. Plus I get to pick the song."

Alice contemplated the addendum to the bargain then shook her head in a motion that sent her blonde hair bobbing about. "It's a deal."

“Good. Mind if I at least order my food first?”

“Don’t you need to look for a song?” Violet pointed out.

“I’ve got a good inclination of what I want to do already,” Nick replied. “I’m quite confident they’ll have my choice. That can be confirmed in a moment; the first priority here is selecting something to fill my cavernous stomach.”

The rest of the table took a lead from his good idea and began pondering their dinner options.

## 99.

Glenn was about fifteen minutes away from Karaoke Barn, forced to come separately from Jill due to his late class, when the stereo on his car dissolved into static. He let out an obligatory curse word and began to fiddle with the knob, paying traffic only a passing nod of attention. No matter how he switched through the stations, everything came in with the same crackling pattern. With a grunt of annoyance he turned off the volume and put his attention back to the road. This was not a good start to the night; he could already feel the agitation growing within his belly.

There was a blast of fresh noise pollution as his radio seemingly turned itself back up to max volume. Glenn tried to mute it once more; however, this time his button manipulations had no effect. After a few seconds, the sound died on its own, and Glenn found himself thankful for at least the blessing of silence. His gratitude was very short-lived.

“Good evening, Glenn.” The voice came crisply over the radio, mild distortion making it impossible to place without interfering with its clarity. Glenn immediately glanced around for the walkie-talkie one of his douche friends had surely hidden in his car.

“You can look all you want, you’re not going to find anything.”

That was kind of creepy. Either the voice on the radio was watching him, or it had taken a very accurate guess at what he would do. Glenn tried to turn the radio off once more, but he wasn’t surprised when it failed to show any result.

“Real funny. Dan, I’m guessing you did this.”

“I’m not Dan, and this isn’t supposed to be funny.”

Glenn swallowed hard. He might not be able to make out the owner of the voice, but he could still hear the hatred that was seething in it. It was trying to scare him, and Glenn didn’t like other people trying to make him feel small.

“Oh yeah, well then you fucked up because it’s funny as hell. Sorry, man, but it takes more than some voice on the radio to scare me.” He’d barely finished this sentence when he noticed the car had begun to drift to the left. There was a concrete barrier only a few feet away, separated from him only

by the small shoulder of a buffer zone. Instinctively Glenn turned the wheel to the right, only to realize that nothing happened. He jerked it hard this time and slammed on the brake for good measure. Nothing.

“Am I still funny, Glenn?”

Glenn felt that hot boil of anger in his stomach suddenly turn into ice. The car was still sliding left, inch by precious inch.

“Who are you? How are you doing this?”

“This is God.”

“Sure it is,” Glenn snapped. The car moved several inches over then pulled back to its leisurely slide.

“I control your future. I decide whether you live or die. My statement might be untrue to the rest of the world, but I’m God to you, Glenn.”

Glenn tried the wheel once more, not expecting to have any impact but twisting it furiously anyway. Whatever this person had done, they’d taken over his car completely. He tried the door and found it unwilling to unlock. Not even the window would roll down. Somewhere inside Glenn cursed himself for getting electric windows.

“What do you want?”

“Glad you’re finally ready to listen,” the voice said. The car pulled back into the lane and resumed a reasonable speed. “I want you to stay away from Jill Murray.”

“Jill? You hijacked my car just to break up me and my girlfriend?” There was a growl from the engine as the car accelerated swiftly.

“God works in mysterious ways. He also can see the future. And the past. Even the past that some courts will seal for minors. He knows about your temper. He knows how you need to maintain control, and how angry you get when you feel like it has slipped away from you. God doesn’t like the way you process your rage, Glenn. God is ending this one before it starts.”

Fury was beginning to overwhelm fear once more. Glenn slammed his hand on the dashboard and yelled at the mysterious voice. “Fuck you! I don’t know what you’ve heard but-”

The car whipped to the left, rushing across the shoulder and pressing against the concrete barrier. The sideview mirror was ripped away in an

instant; the small bit that remained made sparks as it dragged against the cement wall.

“This is not a negotiation. This is a warning, the only warning you’re going to get. Her number has already been stripped from your phone. All calls and texts will be intercepted and responded to in an appropriate breakup manner. You will not go to see her. If she finds you then you will run away as fast as you can. If you should fail to heed any one of my orders then all that will be found of you is a totaled car that reeks of alcohol. No one will investigate, and no one will miss you when you’re gone. God has spoken.”

The car died all at once, righting its direction ever so slightly so it coasted away from the wall but stayed on the shoulder. Glenn’s heart was thundering in his chest, his hands clutching a wheel that had no bearing on what his vehicle did. He was dimly aware that his crotch was warm, and it would be at least ten minutes before he realized he’d pissed himself. The radio was the last piece to go dark, doing so only after one last message flickered out from the dimming system.

“Do. Not. Test. Me.”

\* \* \*

Two miles away Will Murray sat on a lawn chair in a field next to a very strange miniature satellite. It was connected to a console system that would have boggled most minds at an initial glance and nearly all minds upon investigation. He powered down the system and rose from his perch, removing the microphone headset and setting it atop the satellite dish. Glenn would undoubtedly have his car searched top to bottom, but it wouldn’t do any good. The small node used to establish a remote link had already self-destructed into a pile of silver goo. Will couldn’t control electronics the way his sister could, but that wasn’t the same as not being able to control them at all.

As Will packed away his equipment, he wondered if this would be enough. He’d tried to be gentle, using fear over force. Last time there hadn’t been the opportunity for a gentle touch, but hopefully this would be different. Somehow, he doubted it. People like that weren’t ones to give up on what they considered to be their property without a fight. Nothing could be done about it. If Glenn pressed the issue... well, Will had given him fair warning.

Will finished packing and began dragging his things to the car. At least it was a pleasant evening. He wouldn’t even need to change; he could

head right to the party from here.

“They call you Lady Luck, but there is room for doubt. At times you have unladylike waaaay of running out.” Nick let off a quick wink to Alice as he tread casually across the stage, microphone in hand.

“Son of a bitch,” Alice swore under her breath, though none of the other attendees at her table had any trouble figuring out the sentiment of her mumblings.

People often forget that before it was tigers and magic and family-friendly casinos with roller coasters, Vegas was a place where a different sort gathered. It was smoky bars, mafia bosses, and legendary crooners. Those things still existed, of course, just not at their former levels. For one who grew up in the dusty desert town, those weren’t just phantoms of the past; they were roots meant to be respected. Nick had been dozing off to the recorded vocal magic of Old Blue Eyes since he was a baby. While no one would mistake the sunglasses-clad young man singing “Luck Be a Lady” for the immortal entertainer, it was evident he’d put in a lot of effort learning how to work his voice until it pleased all the ears lucky enough to be around it.

“I didn’t know Nick could sing,” Camille said as he belted out the final notes and set the microphone back on the stand.

“Me neither. And I’m positive Alice didn’t,” Vince replied.

The blonde girl was out of her seat before Nick got anywhere near his. With one hand on her hip she took the other and thrust a finger directly into Nick’s sternum. “You tricked me.”

“I said it was embarrassing. It is, having all these eyes worshipping me,” Nick shot back. His tone was defensive, but the smarmy grin plastered across his face said he knew exactly what he had done.

“I’m sure you must have been mortified, the way you pranced around up there.”

“Pranced? Now that’s just mean.” Nick pressed his hand across his heart to show how injured he felt. This led to him brushing Alice’s malice-filled finger that was still drilling into him. She jerked it back as if she were afraid it would be dissolved by his skin. There was a beat of awkward silence between them before Alice sat back down with a huff.



“Whatever. I should have known better than to make a deal with you anyway.”

“I won’t disagree with you there,” Nick said cheerfully. “So, who is going next?”

\* \* \*

“Where the heck is Glenn,” Jill muttered, checking her phone yet again. He had promised to only be a few minutes late, yet the food had already come and gone with no sign of her boyfriend. Even Will had finished his lab and shown up only half an hour late.

“Maybe he got sick or something,” Julia suggested helpfully. In truth she was a bit hungry for conversation; usually she would chat with Sasha, but tonight her super-fast roommate was preoccupied with staring at Vince and flipping through the book of song options. Shane and Chad were at their table, too, but they weren’t much at small-talk. Shane seemed distracted, and Chad was trying, unsuccessfully, to chip in with little blurbs.

“Maybe,” Jill said uncertainly. Her reverie was interrupted by Sasha, who slammed the song book shut with a surprising amount of gusto.

“Found one!” she declared, hopping up from her seat. “Chad, get your vocals warmed up, I’m going to go put our name in the queue.”

“Beg pardon?” Chad’s words might as well not have been spoken since the intended audience was already gone by the time they came out. He looked at the remaining girls with some uncertainty. All they offered up in return was half-hearted shrugs. Julia likely could have explained to him that Sasha had chosen a duet with a good-looking guy just in an attempt to make Vince jealous, however Chad’s befuddlement was the most entertainment Julia had gotten all evening and she wasn’t inclined to see it end just yet.

\* \* \*

“So are you going to sing?” Vince asked Camille as Will mercifully finished butchering a classic Elvis song. He handed off the microphone to Selena, who was waiting stageside since she was next to perform. As she ascended, Sasha and Chad walked over from their table and took her place.

“Not unless someone puts a gun to my head, and even then I’m not making promises,” Camille hurriedly replied. “I don’t really flourish in the spotlight.”

“It’s not my favorite place to be either,” Vince admitted. He might have said more, but it would have been rude to chat over Selena’s singing when they were right by the stage. Her dark-brown eyes flitted through the crowd, landing briefly on Alex, then immediately turning away as the music began to swell. She’d chosen a relatively old one, a song from the nineties about a lost soul searching for its companion. Selena could have used her power to make everyone feel the sorrow as she sang, but she didn’t. She didn’t have to; her talent did that all on its own. Usually there was at least a bit of hushed conversation as someone performed. In that moment, as the heartbroken girl projected her sadness, there wasn’t so much as a peep.

It wasn’t until Selena sang the final note that anyone dared to move in their seats, and at that their first reaction was to applaud wildly. Camille looked over to Vince, intending to continue their conversation, when she encountered quite possibly the last thing she would have expected. A small pool of tears was glistening in Vince’s bright blue eyes, his vision still unwavering from the now-departing songstress.

“Vince?”

The silver-haired boy jerked with a start, as though he had completely let it slip his mind that there were other people around him. “I, um, um, well, this is a little embarrassing.” He fumbled around for a tissue, finding none on the cleared-off tables.

“There’s nothing wrong with the tears. It was a touching performance,” Camille reassured him.

“It was, but that’s not it,” Vince replied, still scouring for something to wipe with. At last he remembered Nick had made him stick a handkerchief in one of his jacket pockets just in case. After a few attempts he pulled it out, along with his pocket watch, from the one on his right front. “The song just reminded me of someone from a long time ago.”

“I see,” Camille said. She resisted the urge to bite her lip as Vince dabbed at his eyes. If she’d been a little less absorbed in his statement she might have heard the sudden movement behind her. It would still have been a stretch, because only a few people in the room were able to follow the burst of motion.

From Vince’s perspective all he felt was a sudden iron grip clamp down on his wrist. He glanced up to see Chad staring down at him, a sea of unspoken emotions contorting his face.

“Where did you get that?” Chad was never what someone would call warm, but his usual tone was positively bubbly compared to how he sounded now.

“The handkerchief?” Vince felt the grip tighten significantly.

“I am not playing games. Where did you get that watch?”

## 101.

“Chad, I think you’re hurting Vince.” Camille’s voice was a stark contrast to the uneasy silence that had fallen over the room when Chad gripped his classmate. Little was said, and tension could be sensed in the bodies of those around them, some worried about what was happening while others were ready to jump into action if the moment called for it. Chad could feel the stares of everyone centering on him, and ordinarily it would have been enough to make him take a step back. Not with this. Even the innocent concern of Camille only resulted in him slightly relaxing his grip, only barely enough to allow blood flow.

“I need an answer, Vince.”

“It was a gift from my father.” Vince had no idea what the hell was going on, but even he was smart enough to see that something was wrong with Chad. The blonde boy had always been reserved in his strength, never lording his superior power over the rest of the class. That didn’t make him perfect, however, and Vince knew firsthand that when someone with real skill lost control things could get very bad, very fast.

“A gift from your father.” Chad’s face looked like it might begin to turn green. “And who is your father, exactly?”

“The man who raised me. I never knew his name; he said he’d cast it away before we met. To me he was always just Father.” In truth, Vince would have preferred not to get into his past in such a public place; but, it seemed like there was no alternative other than to tell Chad the truth. Whatever was happening, lying was bound to make it worse.

“How did he get this?”

“Chad, maybe you want to calm down a little. I don’t think Vince’s history is really your business,” Nick said, eyeing the young man carefully. Hershel had held up a shot of whiskey and Mary had given him a curt nod, so Nick knew both of them were ready to go if things went south. Still, with Chad’s strength, he could rip off Vince’s arm before anyone could react, so diplomacy was currently the strategy of choice.

“How did he get this watch? When did he give it to you?” Chad could hear the other people in the room whispering, but they didn’t exist right now. His world had narrowed down to only himself, a boy with silver hair, and a

gold pocket watch.

“All he told me was that it was a gift from a very dear friend. He passed it on to me when I turned thirteen.”

Chad’s eyes narrowed just a hair. “That’s a lie.”

“It’s what he told me.”

“Then he was lying!” Vince winced as Chad’s grip tightened involuntarily, his grimace of pain causing a shift toward readiness in the people nearest to him.

“It’s what he told me, and I don’t see why he would lie. I’ve told you what I know. Now tell me why this is so important.” Vince met Chad’s stare without wavering. There was sweat beginning to bead below his blonde hair and a small twitch dancing in his right eye. For someone whose power was bodily control to show signs of stress this obvious, there had to be a full-scale war waging inside him. At first Vince didn’t think Chad was going to respond. It was only after he felt the super-strength empowered hand release his wrist that Chad began his explanation.

“There are only two watches like that in the world. They were custom made by a man whose power was metal manipulation. They were sold to his apprentices, two young Heroes who had done their internships under him. Each bought one and then gave them as gifts to one another.” Chad reached into his own suit jacket and produced a pocket watch that was a twin to Vince’s own. Had he not displayed signs of potentially coming unhinged, there might have been a gasp of surprise from the room. As it was, everyone just tried very hard to stay quiet lest they accidentally stir his unstable state. Everyone, that is, except Vince.

“So, our fathers knew each other?”

“The watches were a symbol of their friendship, of all the hardships they’d endured together,” Chad said, ignoring Vince as he gazed down at the golden timepiece in his hand. “That’s what my mother told me, anyway. See, I didn’t get mine handed off to me like you did. I inherited it as part of my father’s estate.”

“He died?”

“He was murdered by the man who carried your watch!” Chad spat angrily. Dimly he was aware of a crunching sound. Had he looked down he

would have noticed he'd just accidentally cracked the concrete floor by shifting his weight. He might have even cared, though by this point it would be hard to say.

"His partner! His best friend! That man drove a spike of energy through my father's chest and left him to die in the street!"

"Oh shit," Alice mumbled as she and Nick exchanged a glance. They hadn't included it in the presentation, but they'd both read up about a man that died in such a way. In an instant they both knew who Chad's father had been.

"Look, I don't know what you think happened," Vince began, but the speed at which Chad whipped his ever-maddening eyes toward Vince stilled the words on his tongue.

"I know exactly what happened. It was extremely well-documented and witnessed. The 'Hero' Globe murdered my father before turning on the rest of his team." This time there were gasps, stifled gasps but gasps none the less. Everyone knew about that incident, but no one had ever realized Intra had a son.

"My father didn't even have powers. He was a wanderer! For heaven's sake, we met when I was digging food out of a trash can!" Vince's own voice was raised as well, and he realized at some point he'd gotten to his feet. There were few things that could easily rile him, but slanderous accusations at the kind man who had taken him in were near the top of the list.

"Which brings us back to how he got that watch!" Chad slammed his unencumbered hand onto the heavy marble table, shattering it at its center and sending half whipping into the air. It began descending almost immediately, its stone surface on a direct crash course with Camille's cranium.

Vince didn't have time to think, not that it would have changed things if he had. Flaring temper or not, his priorities remained intact. He grabbed the birthday girl in his arms and threw her to the ground, putting his spine between her and the table. The last thing he saw before shutting his eyes and waiting for impact was a look of terror rippling across her face. It was a look that would never truly leave him.

The table slammed into Vince's back then slid to the ground with a dull thud.

## 102.

Vince had been heavily injured before; it was a memory that was complex for him due to the other person involved in it. He had some idea of what to expect. Crippling pain, a ripping sensation through his muscles, and numbness that possibly would be there forever, these were all what should have come when the table landed on him.

As he cautiously opened an eye and examined the now largely-crumbled table next to him, he realized that none of that had or would be happening. He felt fine; it was as if the table had barely even touched him. Chad was staring down, his face aghast at the injury he had to believe he'd just caused. If he noticed the confusion on Vince's face, it didn't show in his own horror. Luckily, someone else definitely noticed, and that person sprang into immediate action.

"Nice catch, Mary," Nick said, bounding out of his seat and putting himself between Vince and Chad. Things were calm for the moment, but with topics as sensitive as what they'd been dealing with, a return or an escalation was always possible. No, this situation needed to be guided to resolution and it needed to get there fast.

"Huh?" Mary said, looking at him dumbly from her seat. She, like the others, had been too swept up in the sudden show to fully register everything that was happening. Nick gave her a fierce glare and she snapped back to reality, quickly reading his mind to get a handle on the plan.

"So eloquent when you're concentrating," Nick continued. "Still, it was impressive. I was right by him and I could see you had less than an inch of distance between Vince and the table when you caught it."

"I didn't have much time," Mary said, playing along at last. The looks of uncertainty on the faces of their peers were slowly shifting to understanding. Of course Mary had caught it; she was an incredibly powerful telekinetic, she could make that kind of save.

"Now, as for you," Nick said, turning to Chad. "I think you should leave."

"I'm... I wasn't... I didn't-"

"I have no doubt you didn't mean to almost cripple my friend or

smash the birthday girl's head, but you damn near came close regardless of intention. You were lucky we had a private room so no normal people were around to see it. You're the guy whose power is control, so how about using some of it and walking away from a situation where you know you can't keep a cool head?"

Shane appeared at his friend's side and put a reassuring hand on his shoulder. "Nick is right. Vince isn't going anywhere. You can finish this later, when you're calm."

Chad nodded slowly, his eyes still trained on the two fellow students his single action had almost seriously injured. He hadn't meant to hurt anyone, he'd just felt so... so angry. It had been a long time since his temper had gotten the better of him, and for good reason. When people with his kind of power lost their cool, innocent bystanders almost always got hurt.

"I'm sorry," Chad said softly. He and Shane headed for the door immediately, followed by a few of their classmates who felt the party was probably over from this point on. Nick waited until they were completely gone before offering his friend a hand up. By the time Vince was on his feet, Stella and Violet had pulled Camille up and were checking her for any injury. As for Camille, her eyes never left Vince as he assured his teammates clustering around him that he was okay. The remaining students began to disperse, understandably not quite in a party mood anymore.

Nick slid away from the concerned crowd mobbing Vince, finding himself standing on the fringe of the group with Alice.

"Some night, huh?"

"Never a dull moment with these guys," Nick replied.

"You did a good job calming things down."

"Calm? Things aren't calmed, they're just delayed. Chad pretty much just accused Vince of being raised by the most notorious villain in recent history."

"You're forgetting something," Alice pointed out. "Globe is dead. His team killed him after he murdered Intra."

"That's the story," Nick agreed.

"You don't buy it?"



“I prefer to say I have my doubts. Besides, it would certainly help explain why some random drifter was able to teach Vince to fight so well.”

“I see what you mean. Speaking of seeing, I was at about the same vantage point as you during that fiasco.”

“And?”

“And I know the table didn’t stop an inch from Vince. It hit him full-force,” Alice said.

Nick turned a curious eye to her. He wondered when his former admirer had gotten so observant. It was certainly a useful trait, but one that could create problems in the future. “Yeah, he took it right in the spine. He should have a broken back right now, yet he looks no worse for the wear except for some bruising on his wrist.”

As Nick spoke Camille plowed her way through the crowd and laid a hand on Vince’s hand. The two shared a look of understanding as the red marks on his wrist in the shape of Chad’s hand began to fade and then disappear entirely.

“What do you think it means? Has he been hiding his abilities from us?”

“Vince couldn’t hide water in the ocean. It’s not who he is. Besides, he was more surprised than we were when this night didn’t end with him in traction,” Nick explained.

“So it’s something new then, like what happened with me?”

“If I were a betting man, and I am, that’s where I’d lay my odds. We can tackle that tomorrow. Right now we should really get him home so he can calm down.”

“He looks fine,” Alice said. Nick smiled inwardly at her words. If she hadn’t noticed the small tremors in Vince’s hands or the nervous way he was licking his lips then her observation skills were still at a manageable level.

“Trust me, he’s putting on a brave front. We need to get him home.” With that, Nick stepped forward and began herding the crowd with kind words and frequent assurance. He gave his apologies to the birthday girl but was insistent that they all head out. Some were electing to stay and keep the party rolling, however Nick spared his people from obligation with excuses, false commitments, and just the right amount of guilt. It took nearly ten

minutes, but in the end, all of Team One was heading toward their respective dorms, an uncharacteristically silent Vince left alone to unwind in the back of Nick's car.

That was the end of their party. For two of them, it was not quite yet the end of their night.

## 103.

Vince stepped back into his room after a long shower, only to find his phone vibrating aggressively across his desk as the screen flashed an unfamiliar number. He let it bounce around the wooden surface as he got dressed, not in a mood to talk to anyone, regardless of who was calling. Eventually the phone ceased its rattling, only to begin once more mere moments later. He let this call extinguish, too; however, when it began again he couldn't take it any longer.

"Hello?" He tried to sound curt, but deep down he suspected he merely came off as tired.

"Hey. I'm outside your dorm's front door. Come let me in already."

Although the caller couldn't see it, Vince's face furrowed in uncertainty. He was pretty sure he recognized the voice, but he had no idea why that person would be calling on him so late. Ultimately, Vince wasn't one to turn away someone in need, even if his own night had been a spectacular shitshow.

"I'll be right out." He closed the phone and headed out of his room. Both the boys' lounge and the common room were empty, as he'd expected. No one else had been up for keeping the night going after the inadvertent showdown at the Karaoke Barn. Well, almost no one, anyway. He went down the entrance hall and pushed the front door open. While a finger print was required to get in, getting out was less secured. This was, allegedly, in case of an emergency that required immediate evacuation. A small figure trundled through the open door, arms heavy with several grocery bags that likely would not have been so cumbersome on a larger person.

"Is everything okay?" Vince asked.

"I'd say it's far from it," the figure responded. It set down a few of its burdens, revealing Camille's delicate features and pale blonde hair. Vince obliged his male duties by scooping up the bags she let down, a quick peek showing him one was filled with junk food and the other various drinks in aluminum cans.

"If this is about the party, I'm really sor-"

Camille held up a now free hand to silence him. "First off, you threw

yourself between me and life-threatening injury less than two hours ago, so even if I had been mad at you, we'd already be even. Secondly, what happened tonight was Chad's fault, not yours. He flipped out and you were just trying to keep up. Lastly, I'm not here because anything is wrong with me. I'm here because things are pretty wrong with you."

Vince blinked in surprise. He couldn't remember the last time Camille said that many words in one go, let alone that many to him. She was holding herself taller than usual, too; not that it made much difference on her minimal height, but it was still noticeable. Had he been awake for her fight in the first team event, he would have recognized the tone and posture. As it was, he didn't quite know what to think of it.

"I'm fine," he said at last. "I mean, tonight was really weird and all, but I'll be okay."

"Merde," Camille replied, moving her way past him and into the common room.

"What does that mean?"

"Roughly translated from French, it's a very emphatic version of 'bullshit.' My mother was a second-generation American from Paris, if you couldn't guess from my first name." Camille made it to the coffee table and began depositing her remaining bags across its plentiful surface.

"Look, Camille, I appreciate your concern, but it is really late and I kind of want to--"

"Toss and turn? Lay awake until dawn and gaze at the ceiling? Maybe stare at your watch until you can barely even focus your eyes anymore? If you were going to say one of those, then go ahead, I'll believe it. But don't insult me with some lie about going to sleep. We both know that isn't going to happen."

Vince had no response at the ready; she'd nailed him flat to the wall. While his body was weary and he suspected nothing would feel better than dozing off, deep down he knew the minute he closed his eyes all the questions would come bubbling up. There was so much about Father that Vince didn't know, and while he certainly couldn't believe the man who raised him had been involved with someone like Globe, it did seem evident that there was more to the wanderer than one might have originally suspected. A part of him had always wondered, only now instead of a dulling curiosity, it was evolving into a burning ember of uncertainty.

“You’re not a big drinker, are you?” Camille’s question snapped Vince from the reverie he’d drifted into.

“Not since Thomas’s party, no. That was enough for me.”

“I figured as much, but I brought a six-pack anyway,” Camille said, setting down a carton of glass bottles that were already beginning to show condensation in the warmth of the dorm. While Vince had been musing she’d also unpacked sodas, chips, marshmallows, cards, board games, and a small stack of DVDs. The bags had been stuffed into one another, so now only a single bloated plastic container remained.

“What is all this?”

“Distractions. Things to keep us occupied. I figured you might want to talk about stuff, or you might want very emphatically to not talk about stuff. The first one is easy, the second one usually requires supplies, so I came prepared for either.”

“You didn’t need to do all this.” Vince sat down slowly on the couch, still absorbing the deviation his night had taken from the plan of sleep.

“I’m the healer of this team, and I take that job seriously,” Camille replied, pulling open one of the bags of chips. “But not all damage is physical, you know. Sometimes the wounds you get are in places not even a Super can see. Those scars still need tending, probably even more than the purely physical ones. If I couldn’t tell when one of my teammates was dealing with an old injury then I wouldn’t be much of a healer, would I?” Camille crunched through a corn-chip and gave him a smile. He gazed back at her with a gratitude far beyond his meager vocabulary’s ability to express.

Looking into his eyes still made her feel flustered, still made her want to blush and hush and hide until his attention had turned elsewhere. Camille was still trapped under the weight of her own feelings for him, but at times like this, she could bear it. When he needed her, when he needed protection and help, she was no longer quite crushed by the burden of loving him.

“This... this is really nice of you.”

“I already told you, we’re teammates. And even if we weren’t, you’re my friend.”

“Still, it means a lot. I think I’d like to not talk. At least, not at first.”

“I suspected as much.” Camille reached down and shifted through the

stacks of DVDs. “I don’t know what you usually watch, but I brought action, comedy, sci-fi, horror-”

“Anything but horror,” Vince said immediately.

“Oh yeah, I forgot about Nick’s slasher marathons.”

“Then consider yourself extremely lucky,” Vince shot back, reaching out and grabbing a handful of chips himself. Camille popped in a comedy and settled into a recliner as the opening menu appeared on screen. Part of her wished she had the courage to sit with him on the couch, where they might accidentally touch or fall asleep next to one another. Even if she could have done it, she probably wouldn’t have. Tonight was about making Vince’s life feel less complicated, not more.

\* \* \*

Nick was the first one up the next morning, passing through the common room on his way to the kitchen for coffee. As soon as he stepped through the door he saw Vince passed out on the couch, a bag of marshmallows spilling out of his hands and likely already attracting ants. Camille was asleep in the chair, a throw blanket pulled up tight over her small body. Although they were several pieces of furniture apart, he could see they were much closer than they had been when seated next to one another.

“About time,” Nick mumbled as he continued his trek to the kitchen. He’d deal with this new situation in whatever way he deemed best, but only after coffee.

“You know, this isn’t as bad as I expected.” Alice surveyed the porcelain domain, rubber gloves pulled tight across her hands and an already-soapy mop to her side. She’d picked out the grittiest clothes she had for this job: a t-shirt and sweatpants that were each designer label but from a collection now three years old. Most of the morning had been spent getting supplies and bracing for the worst, but the room before her was actually not as horrific as tales of men’s restrooms had led her to believe.

“We do have a cleaning lady that comes every few days,” Nick reminded her. “Melbrook might be cozy and odd but it’s still a dorm. Besides, there’s less mess when you have three guys who know each other sharing the same area. Not much opportunity for diffused responsibility.”

“I don’t want to know,” Alice said immediately. “I’m here to clean, not learn anything more about what goes on in here than I have to.”

“Fair enough. I must say, I’m surprised you still showed up for this after my mild deception.”

“You mean the fact that your singing is fantastic? Yeah, I’ll admit I thought about welching after that little revelation.”

“Stopped by a refined sense of honor?”

“Closer to pride,” Alice admitted. “When I thought about it, you were clearly leading me into this trap. The bathroom was my idea, but it could have been anything. I should have seen it; hell, you weren’t even really trying that hard. So that’s most of why I’m here. Like you said at the slasher marathon, lessons without consequences don’t take as well. This is my way of learning not to be fooled quite so easily.”

“There’s a bit of wisdom in such a philosophy,” Nick said, patting her gently on the shoulder. “Would you like me to keep you company?”

“Much as I’m sure you’d love to ogle my ass when I crouch down in these sweatpants, you’re out of luck. Mary flagged me on my way over. She said she wants to have a chat with you, captain to tactician,” Alice replied.

“This must be my lucky day,” Nick mumbled. He’d known this talk would be coming eventually, he’d just hoped to push it off as long as possible. Mary wasn’t going to like what he had to say, not at all. “Fine, I’ll go get my

lickings.”

“Heh heh. And here I thought I’d be having the worst Saturday out of us all,” Alice chuckled. She pulled the mop clear from the bucket and plopped it onto the tile floor, a wave of bubble-infested water rushing outwards. Nick took a quick step back to keep it from getting on his shoes. He paused for just a moment to savor the sight of oh-so-proper Alice dragging a cleaning implement across the floor, then left the bathroom and headed toward the common area.

Mary was waiting for him as soon as he walked in; a book sat in her lap, clearly not being read. She glanced up and nodded to the seat across from her.

“Shouldn’t we go somewhere more private?”

“Vince and Camille went to get lunch, Roy is off doing more training, and Alice is on cleaning duty. I think we’re okay,” Mary said, nodding to the seat again. “Incidentally, when did those two start hanging out by themselves?”

“I think our little healer was working a different kind of ability last night after the party,” Nick replied. He gave in to her request before it became an order and took the seat she wanted him to. “Vince was visibly shaken up; I assume she came over and helped him feel better.”

“Feels like that should have been our job,” Mary pointed out.

Nick shook his head. “Vince doesn’t deal with vulnerability well. He admits his own weakness, faces his own faults, and even cops to his failings better than anyone else I know, but the kid hates having people worry about him. If we’d tried, all we would have done is get him to dig in deeper, insisting he was okay. Camille is nothing but vulnerability; my guess is something about that gentle demeanor of hers was enough to slip through his guard.”

“As long as he’s okay. While we’re on the subject of Vince...”

“I know you didn’t catch the table,” Nick said.

“I figured. So what happened?”

Nick shifted a bit in his seat. “How much do you know about Vince, before the procedure?”



“I’m going to guess less than you.”

“That’s a given. I meant about his ability. Did you know that when Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport found him, Vince was locked in a concrete bunker because he was going through a phase where he absorbed almost every kind of energy he touched? Heat, electricity, even sunlight.”

“Vince can absorb light? He’s never done that before.”

“Exactly. When he got control, he focused on energies that were very finite. Contained sources that would run themselves out. It’s why he still uses batteries to get electricity instead of just draining some from a power grid. He’s a little afraid of what he can do, even a year and a half later,” Nick explained.

“That still doesn’t tell me anything about last night.”

“It tells you quite a bit, actually. We know Vince can absorb more than he’s shown us so far. We know a table stopped as soon as it touched him, and that a blow that should have broken his back didn’t leave so much as a bruise. Most importantly, we know he was putting his body between another person and danger, and when Vince is protecting someone, he demonstrates a much higher level of skill with his abilities.”

“You think he absorbed the kinetic energy of the table?” Mary’s eyes had grown wide in disbelief.

“It’s the best theory I have, at the moment. We’ll need to confirm it, but we might want to let him mentally stabilize a bit first. Give him a couple of days and all three of us can have a nice little talk.”

“I agree, he needs time, but I’m not sure how many days we’ve got,” Mary replied. “You know I didn’t call you here just to talk about Vince.”

“You want to know why I haven’t called a strategy meeting for the upcoming match,” Nick surmised.

“Or even come to pitch ideas at me,” Mary added. “Last time you were all about driving home the importance of tactics, but this round you haven’t said word one. What’s going on?”

“Firstly, last time I had to lay down the basics of team-building and get people accustomed to thinking in the right ways,” Nick pointed out. “Secondly, I do have a strategy for this round. It just doesn’t require meetings.”

“How does that work?”

“Let’s move to the kitchen,” Nick said, tilting his head slightly as he strained his ears. “This part needs to be private; I don’t want anyone walking in accidentally.”

“Is it that bad?”

“Let’s say you’re going to require a fair amount of convincing.”

"I appreciate you all coming on such short notice," Dean Blaine said, greeting the four men already waiting in his office. He'd meant to be here when they arrived; however, it seemed the board that presided over Lander wasn't content with reaming him for just a few minutes. They'd demanded a full hour of his time for interrogation. Dealing with bureaucrats made him miss his Hero days, back when someone trying to get information out of you only involved a few bouts of light torture. In business things were not nearly so civilized.

"Yeah, well, nothing like the name 'Globe' to get people running," Professor Pendleton said from his chair. He looked relaxed to the untrained eye, which might have been more useful had any eye in the room not been extensively trained. Professor Fletcher sat next to him, his own posture visibly tense. Across from them, Mr. Transport wore an expression of concern while Mr. Numbers worked very hard to ascertain every detail of their situation.

"Nothing indeed," Dean Blaine agreed. He paused as he went to his desk, tempted for a moment to pour a tall drink for himself and his guests. A heartbeat's hesitation decided against it. This day was still young, and he might well need his wits about him. "As you all know, there was an outburst last night amidst some of the sophomore class. During this incident, Chad Taylor leveled accusations that the man who raised Vince Reynolds either may have been or might have had some connection to the criminal known as Globe."

"Globe, who has been dead nearly sixteen years by my count," Professor Fletcher pointed out.

"It's not like we've never seen someone fake their own death before," Professor Pendleton said. "Hell, I think I had a villain who pulled it off four times before one of his plans went a little awry and he ended up in the ground for real."

"Yes, but Globe was killed in full view of hundreds of witnesses, by his own former team at that," Mr. Numbers countered. "I'll admit that since it was Black Hole who did the deed, it presents us with the lack of a corpse; however, every possible verification method possible was undertaken and all confirmed Globe's demise."

“Did you ever deal with Globe?” Professor Pendleton asked.

“No. He was a Hero, and my job requires interaction with the other side of the spectrum,” Mr. Numbers admitted.

“Blaine and I did. We were in the same class, we graduated with him, and we knew him like family,” Professor Pendleton said. “Trust me when I say that if anyone could have pulled off the fake death in that situation, it was him.”

“While I won’t disagree with Professor Pendleton’s analysis of Globe’s skill level, that is not our most pressing concern,” Dean Blaine interrupted. “The current issue is that the board feels that training someone who might be the son, biological or not, of the world’s most well-known turncoat could turn into a PR nightmare. Not only for us, but for Mr. Reynolds himself.”

“Now hang on: there’s been a long standing precedent for letting children of villains into the HCP,” Mr. Transport objected. “There’s even a rule against discriminating against someone because of their parents’ actions.”

“It’s called the ‘Sins of the Fathers’ clause,” Professor Pendleton supplied helpfully.

“Right. So how can they put pressure on you to drum someone out in violation of their own rules?”

“No one has put that pressure on me. Yet,” Dean Blaine replied. “It has only been hinted at. No, right now I am merely being tasked with investigating the truth of these claims. The board considers it imperative that we know exactly who raised Mr. Reynolds and what, if any, his connection to Globe was.”

“And what if, worst case scenario, his father was Globe?” Professor Fletcher asked.

“Then things become decidedly more complicated,” Dean Blaine admitted.

“That’s bullshit!” Mr. Transport rose from his seat, barely resisting the urge to slam his hand on the dean’s desk. He knew Mr. Numbers would chastise him later for showing his emotions so easily, but at the moment that didn’t matter one bit. “Vince got into this program on his own merits and he’s stayed in by his own skill and determination. No one has the right to take that

from him just because of the man who raised him.”

“Nor would they, not officially,” Dean Blaine shot back. “Mr. Reynolds is a talented young man, but he is not exactly leading the pack. His primary role in any team would be as a combatant, yet if one looked at the best warriors in the class, regardless of gender, his record would place him far from even the top five.”

“That’s enough to cut him?” Professor Fletcher asked uncertainly.

“On its own, not yet. He’d usually get to run through his third year before being middle of the pack wasn’t good enough. With the controversy over his group being former Powered, they’re already being looked at more closely than the others. If we were to determine he was linked in an unfavorable way to Globe... I’m afraid I only have so much sway over the decisions of the board,” Dean Blaine said with a sad shake of his head. “All we can do is hope that such a link does not exist. The board won’t press me too hard on just speculation, at least that’s my hope.”

“Which brings us to why we’re all here,” Professor Pendleton, picking up the topic. “I can’t help but notice you only called in people you either trust or believe to have the best interests of those kids at heart.”

“I have a headache bigger than your ego from dealing with this situation already. Just ask what you want to ask.”

“Are we here to investigate that link, or to cover it up?”

There was a snap of silence as the others waited for the dean’s response. For his part he spent a full ten seconds reflecting on how much he wished he’d stopped to pour that drink.

“You are here to get to the truth,” Dean Blaine said at last. “While I may not like what will come from it, I am not in the habit of dealing in lies. Our duty is to find out everything we can and then do our best to make sure an innocent boy is not unduly punished for it.”

“That is all well and good,” Mr. Numbers said. “But what it doesn’t tell us is why you only summoned us to this meeting. It seems like the rest of the professors would be just as capable at the task you’re presenting.”

“Unfortunately that would be because of another strike against Mr. Reynolds, one that casts suspicion on the validity of his admission, and one of which even he is not aware,” Dean Blaine explained. “None of you have sat

in on the conference we hold deciding which applicants are allowed into the freshman class of the HCP, but the process is actually quite simple. The dean and the active professors gather together to review files of those who meet basic requirements, then a vote is taken on each candidate as to whether reject or admit them. Additionally, each professor has the ability to speak before the votes and have one student instantly accepted or rejected. We refer to this as their 'auto' and each voter only has one per year. This allows them to bank on hunches or permit admittance of candidates that they see potential in where others do not."

"Seems fair," Professor Fletcher noted.

"It is a process that strives for just that description. Anyway, Vince Reynolds was brought into the HCP because of a professor's auto. His admission was never voted on directly."

"So what's the problem? You just told us that was a valid part of the admission process," Mr. Transport said.

"The issue is not that an auto was cast for him. The issue is the voter who cast it. It was cast by a professor who had not used an auto in over eleven years, who had professed he never saw candidates worthy enough to deserve his nod. The man who opened a wide door for Vince into our HCP was one of the attempted kidnappers of Mary Smith. It was George Russell."

The knock on Chad's door didn't exactly send it flying off the hinges, but it landed with enough force to make it clear that the possibility was definitely there. He glanced up from his bed and then rolled over. Whoever it was could go away. Chad hadn't opened the door for Shane, who had tried first thing that morning, or Angela, who had come about an hour later, so he certainly wasn't going to disrupt his solitude for someone who didn't even bother announcing their name. The early afternoon sun was beginning to shine through the grubby exterior of his dorm's window, and Chad knew eventually he'd have to leave for food. That was later, when the rest of the school was asleep. Until then, he'd turned off his brain's ability to feel hunger.

A second knock landed, this one sending bits of wood dust hurtling off the top of the door. If they increased at this rate, the visitor's hand would go through the cheap wood in no time.

"Go away." Chad commanded, his head still buried in the pillow. The response was knocking that immediately became persistent and unyielding. Now that they knew he was here, it seemed the strategy was to annoy him into answering. Chad could turn himself deaf and go back to sleep; however, the way the door seemed to be shuddering told him eventually it would cave, and then he really wouldn't be able to get any privacy. With a fluid leap from the bed, he crossed the room in one stride and yanked open his door.

"Afternoon," greeted Roy, left hand still raised while his right clutched a small burlap bag.

"Go away," Chad repeated. "I'm in no mood for visitors."

"I bet you're not," Roy agreed, sliding the tip of his boot a few inches forward. Chad could still slam the door in his face, but now it would shatter the bottom of it and Roy would be unharmed. "After a scene like yours I'd probably be hiding in my room, too."

"I am not hiding. I merely wanted to take some time to reflect on my actions."

"Lucky you, I happen to have an excellent reflection assistant." Roy lifted the canvas bag as illustration.

“I’d rather be alone.”

“I’d rather be spending the day with a supermodel. We all got shit we want.”

“You aren’t going to leave, are you?”

“Nope, and you can’t beat me senseless in the middle of the dorms without witnesses and giving yourself a hell of a lot more to worry about. So just let me in, hear me out, and then you can sulk in the dark all you want.”

Chad stepped aside without so much as a sigh. He’d fought Roy enough to know there was no changing his mind once he set it on something. There was still the option of incapacitating him, but Roy was correct in his assessment that it would result in significant collateral damage.

Chad’s unwanted guest plopped down in a chair and opened his canvas sack, pulling out a long brown bottle and two identical glasses. He twisted off the top and poured each glass about halfway full. Chad accepted the glass handed to him and took a seat, though he didn’t make any motions to drink from it.

“So. You’re the son of Intra.”

“Yes.” There was little point in denying it; everyone in the HCP would likely know by now.

Roy took a slow sip from his drink. “I know how that can wear on you, having that famous pedigree hanging over your head. For most children of big Heroes it’s about measuring up, about not being a failure in comparison. You and I are in a different boat. We’re both set on surpassing ours.”

“Was your father murdered by his best friend, too?”

“No. Abandoned my mother and me when I was a kid. She says she told him to go, that she wanted him to be happy, but even if that’s true he should have known it would destroy... I’m sorry. This isn’t about me. Point is, I know what it’s like to have issues with a missing dad. Not the same as yours, but still, issues.”

“Your camaraderie is noted,” Chad said. He took a gulp of the glass he was holding without thinking about it. It wasn’t as bad as he’d expected: smoother, at least, than others had led him to believe. Had Chad known anything about whiskey, he would have realized that this was more palatable



because Roy had actually brought a decent grade.

“Look, I get that you’re upset about losing control last night, but you need to get over it. People get pissed off and do dumb shit. No one got hurt, so let yourself relax a little.”

“You don’t know the first thing about me,” Chad snapped.

“Yeah, it doesn’t take a genius to figure out that the guy whose power is all about self-control might not handle an emotional freak-out too well,” Roy replied. “Especially when he almost knocked the brains out of an innocent person who happened to be nearby.”

Chad slumped in his chair by a few inches and took another sip of the whiskey. “How is she?”

“Fine, as is Vince, thanks for asking.”

Chad’s head jerked up and his body tightened. “Vince-”

“Vince is a guy with a watch. Maybe it means his hobo dad was actually Globe in disguise. Maybe it means he found it on the ground or looted a corpse years earlier. Maybe he bought it at a pawn shop. I don’t know and neither does Vince. For that matter, neither do you.”

“You want me to leave him alone. That’s why you came.”

“I want you to get a grip,” Roy clarified, draining his glass and pouring another. “You almost killed someone last night because of a watch and questions that were honestly answered. I realize your dad is a sore issue, I really do get that, but you can’t let that send you off the deep end every time. You are way too powerful for that. People will get hurt.”

“People will get hurt.” Chad echoed. He polished off his own glass and held it out for a refill, which Roy obliged.

“And you know that. My money says that’s why you work so hard to stay in control, why you keep a distance from all but the strongest people. You’re scared of slipping up, like last night.”

This time all Chad could do was nod.

“It’s kind of funny; you and Vince are actually really similar. Both brilliant fighters, both dense as bricks when it comes to the social world, and both scared to death of hurting other people involuntarily. Oh, and both of you lost your fathers.”

“His father is dead?”

“When he was thirteen. Watched him get blown up in a train car explosion. So even if that guy was Globe - and if it was then a whole lot of other shit doesn’t make sense - but if it was then he’s already dead.”

“I see.”

“No, you don’t. You don’t believe me, and that’s okay. I’m not here to convince you. I’m just here to get you drunk and help you come to terms with last night’s fiasco.”

“I don’t get drunk. I’ve always just sent the alcohol directly to my bladder.”

“Maybe give the bloodstream a shot this time,” Roy suggested. “Or don’t. Your call.”

They sat in silence for a few minutes after that, the sun making the shadows shift as it descended through the sky. Eventually Chad spoke up, realizing there something they had touched on in the discussion he was still curious about.

“I just realized: you implied your dad was a well-known Hero as well. Who was he?”

Roy had a nearly full glass, which he drained in a single swig before replying. “Titan.”

“Your father was Titan?”

“Yeah.”

“Oh,” Chad said softly. “I can see how that would leave you feeling a bit fucked up.”

## 107.

The others had left the office after the meeting was done, but Professor Pendleton lingered. Dean Blaine didn't admonish him or even encourage him to vacate. Instead he poured two healthy glasses of dark liquor and slid one to his employee. The day's revelations, real or not, struck home for these two in a way the others couldn't truly understand. Globe might not be dead. That was a game changer. Especially for his former classmates.

"I always said it was fishy. We've been around too long to know that you can never confirm a kill without the body."

"Localized gravitational vortexes don't leave much evidence," Dean Blaine pointed out.

"They also shouldn't affect someone with Globe's power."

"I think having his arm torn off would distract even the most focused of minds."

"Maybe," Professor Pendleton conceded.

"Maybe," Dean Blaine agreed.

Both men sipped their drinks in silence for a few moments. Professor Pendleton shifted uncomfortably. "You know what gives me the shivers? I mean, the real, deep-down-in-my gut quake of fear that it might be him?"

"Do tell."

"The kid. Vince. If Globe did somehow survive and go live off the grid as a hobo, the smart thing to do would be staying alone. Minimize exposure. Picking up some child, some Powered child at that, and raising him as your own, tactically it makes no sense. It would be a tremendous risk with no logistical upside."

"All true," Dean Blaine concurred.

Professor Pendleton took another gulp of his drink. "And it's exactly the kind of thing Globe would do."

"He was always the best of us."

"Until he killed Intra," Professor Pendleton pointed out.

“There is one upside to this if he is alive, you know. We have a chance to get answers, to find out why he did it.”

“I’m not sure that’s really an upside.”

“How so?”

“Because if whatever it was could drive someone as decent and powerful as Globe to do all this, I’m afraid those might be answers we don’t want.”

Dean Blaine didn’t have a reply at the ready for that. Instead he topped off both their glasses. Staring into the swirling brown depths, he realized how little sense his world made anymore. Things had been so different only a few decades ago.

“Globe,” he muttered to himself.

\* \* \*

“Globe?”

“Yeah, because of how my powers affect things in a radius,” Blaine explained.

“They do, but you also have that direct attack thing you can do. I remember when you made Victor spend a whole weekend as a human. I thought he was going to climb the walls by the time his power came back,” Joshua chuckled.

Blaine laughed too. It might have been a bit harsh, but Victor had downed all of their beer and thrown up on the sofa. It seemed like a harmless way to get some revenge.

“So you don’t like it?”

“It’s not that; I guess it just doesn’t seem like it fits you,” Joshua explained.

“Well, let’s hear the one you’ve been kicking around then.”

Joshua flashed him that award-winning smile. “Intra,” he said, spreading his hands out as if he was framing the word.

“And you gave me guff over Globe?”

“Think about it. Intra literally means ‘within.’ What better way to

encapsulate my abilities?”

“I don’t know, how about Molecular Control Man?” Blaine tossed out.

“First off, I control my body down to a molecular level, but it’s more than just shifting atoms around. Secondly, there already is a Molecule Man.”

“There is?”

“Yeah, new guy that works in Seattle,” Joshua elaborated.

“I’m out of touch.”

“Most seniors have bigger stuff on their mind. Only reason I remembered is because of my recall.”

Blaine nodded. He hated Joshua a bit for that aspect of his abilities. Being able to conjure any memory perfectly at will made school almost a waste of time for Joshua. He could read the textbook on the first day of class, skip the rest, and still ace every test. Not that he ever did: he was prompt and studious in every endeavor. Somehow that just made it worse.

“Well, if Globe is so bad, what would you recommend?”

“Again, it’s not bad, it’s just not right for you,” Joshua protested. “If I had to think of a good name for you I’d go with something like Zero.”

Blaine’s eyes narrowed and his good humor began to evaporate.

“Oh, don’t give me that look. I don’t mean as an insult. I mean it like a mathematical zero.”

“Explain.”

“Basic multiplication,” Joshua said, turning and taking in the view off Clarissa’s balcony once more. “Anything you multiply by zero becomes zero. It turns any number, no matter how large, into an empty theoretical hole. That’s kind of what you do to the rest of us.”

“By that explanation I’m also an empty hole, seeing as I am the zero they interact with.”

“Somebody is feeling sensitive tonight. It’s just supposed to be symbolic.”

“It seems like a stretch.”

“Better than going literal. Or do you fancy being known as The

Deactivator? Perhaps something a little sportier, like Power Down?” Joshua suggested.

“Okay, okay, you’ve made your point. I still think I can do better than Zero.”

“Find what fits you best,” Joshua said. “Then ignore anybody who doesn’t get it. That’s what I’m trying to do.”

“So I should stick with Globe?”

“God, no.”

They shared a laugh at that, and Joshua turned to head back inside. Miriam would be waiting for him with a warm kiss that tasted like peppermint. Blaine still remembered that flavor; there were nights he woke from a good dream and swore he could taste it on his lips. Those kisses belonged to Joshua now. The only ones Blaine could still enjoy were in the better-preserved portions of his memories. He tried very hard not to be bitter about the happy greeting that Joshua was going back to. Sometimes he almost succeeded.

“Hey, let me know if you do decide to use something other than Globe,” Joshua tossed over his shoulder as he reached the door.

“Why?”

“Well, it’s a bad fit for you, but I think it would be perfect for someone else.”

Blaine didn’t have to think hard to figure out who Joshua meant.

“Tell him he can have it.”

“You sure?”

“Yeah. I’ll find something that feels more like me.”

“Thanks, Blaine, you’re a solid guy.” Joshua shut the door carefully behind him, leaving Blaine alone with the balcony once again.

He stared off at the California sky and tried not to think about how right now the woman he loved was wrapping her arms around that blonde bastard’s shoulders and pulling herself close to him. Part of him wanted to kick the door down and scream about how she had made a mistake. Part of him wanted to leap off this balcony just so he would feel like he was doing

something. Part of him wanted to cry. Instead he just kept staring at the sky.

“Zero.” Blaine tested the word on his tongue. It seemed curiously appropriate, because at this moment that was exactly what he felt like. A nothing. A forgotten, empty hole.

A zero.

By Wednesday things had calmed down a bit for Nick. He'd gotten his plan outlined for Mary, who was finally beginning to warm up to it; he had helped explain their theory of his new power to Vince, who was confused but open-minded; and he had turned in his tailing assignment for Professor Pendleton's class. He'd done nearly all of the legwork before Camille's party, yet it still felt good to have the papers handed in so they could be marveled at. Nick enjoyed the written assignments; they were the one area where he didn't have to diminish his own performance for the sake of keeping character. Sometimes the professor would even call him in to talk about the methods he'd used to achieve such results. Therefore it didn't surprise him when he noticed his daily cipher instructed him to be at class half an hour early. What did surprise him was when he arrived to find both Professor Pendleton and Alice waiting for him.

"You know, if you're going to stage an intervention, I think you need more than two people," Nick pointed out.

"Can you throw an intervention because someone is a douche? Damn, I'd have put one together for you in our first week if I'd known that," Alice countered.

"Cute as your verbal dry-humping is, I think you both know why I've called you here," Professor Pendleton interrupted. He pulled two stapled stacks of paper from his desk.

"No idea," Nick replied, for once, honestly.

"It's because we turned in the same tailing assignment," Alice said.

"Wrong, it is because you both turned in the same... wait, what?"

"Well, virtually the same, I mean. Nick probably had a few Watches I didn't, and I know I had a bunch of Spots that weren't on his."

"I am just so very confused," Nick said.

Professor Pendleton held up the twin stacks of paper, which Nick now recognized as their respective tailing assignments. As he looked at the first page he realized something; Alice's was identical to his own save only for name and penmanship.



“I know you two are teammates, and I do respect a desire to help each other out; however, you must know that even in a class as morally grey as mine you cannot allow another student to copy your work. This undermines the act of learning, which is what you are here to do.”

“Professor, I didn’t let Alice copy my work,” Nick protested.

“He really didn’t,” Alice confirmed.

“Oh? Then how did you happen to provide near identical Watches to his?”

“I stole them.”

“You stole them.”

“I stole them,” she repeated.

“How the hell did you steal my answers?” Nick asked.

“Remember when you left me alone to clean the boy’s bathroom this weekend?”

“Yes, but I only let you into the bathroom. All of my notes were in my bedroom,” Nick pointed out.

“Yeah, fun fact. When your father pays for, facilitates, and largely lets you design the building you live in, getting universal access on all the doors actually isn’t that hard.”

“Then how... oh, you wily girl,” Nick said, realization dawning at last.

“Would someone care to explain the rest of this to me?” Professor Pendleton said.

“Friday night Nick pretended he was bad at singing so I’d beg him to get on stage and do karaoke,” Alice summarized. “In return he wanted me to do something humiliating as well. I floated the idea of cleaning the boys’ bathroom, and he accepted. When it turned out he could sing, I pouted and acted pissed, so he felt good enough about his little trick that he never thought twice about leaving me on the boys’ side unattended. I also took the precaution to make sure he’d leave by reminding our captain she hadn’t gotten his plans for the upcoming match yet. After that, it was just a matter of opening the door and taking a few photos with my cell phone.”

“So you knew I could sing?”

“I suspected, but it didn’t really matter. We weren’t making a bet, we were striking a deal, so I was obliged regardless. You were very careful to structure it that way.” Alice flashed him a smile that Nick was quite accustomed to giving and not so accustomed to seeing on other people.

“A daring and well-crafted plan,” Professor Pendleton said. “Sadly, it has nothing to do with tailing, which was the assignment.”

“The assignment was to get information, which I did. Quite a lot of it, actually: well over twenty points, even if none of my Spots count.”

“Yet you stole the vast bulk of it from another student’s efforts. What on earth would make you think that was acceptable?”

In response Alice pulled out and unfolded a slip of paper from her uniform’s pocket then slapped it on the desk. It was the syllabus from the first day of Subtlety class. Her well-manicured nail pointed at the third entry, a single word in bold print: “Cheat.”

“Ms. Adair, this does not-”

“I created a plan with multiple steps, I used a person’s own trick against them, I adapted to changing circumstances on the fly, and I executed it all without my target’s knowledge. The goal of this class exercise was information gathering. Tailing was just the recommended technique. Or is it your contention that methods are more important than results?”

Professor Pendleton looked over at Nick, who could only shrug. Nearly everything she’d said were Professor Pendleton’s own words and wisdom that had been dispersed throughout his class lectures. He turned his attention back to the near identical submissions and took in a very deep breath.

“Fine,” Professor Pendleton said at last. “However, if this ever happens again, I’ll be giving you a zero, Nick.”

“Who to the what now?”

“You heard me. She caught me by surprise with this stunt too, so I can hardly hold you to a higher standard. From here on it’s a different story. If you don’t guard your information then you give your enemy the advantage. So if she manages to steal your stuff again then you’ll get a zero,” Professor Pendleton explained.

“What about the extra challenge to skip the final?” Alice asked.

“After your next team event. I’ll need to get the necessary permissions and, of course, finish grading, just in case anyone else qualified. Now both of you go take a walk before class. I don’t feel like entertaining you.”

Alice and Nick took the hint and retreated into the hallway immediately. As they walked down the concrete corridors, Nick looked at the blonde girl with a new respect. She had played him. Not for anything important, and not all that well by his standards, but she’d still managed to slip one by him.

“Question,” Nick said. “You couldn’t have known I’d give you that golden opportunity last week when you asked all those questions about exceeding the point total on the assignment. So what was your original plan?”

“I had faith that at some point you’d set me up, especially at a nice social setting,” Alice replied. “I did have a backup plan in case you didn’t.”

“What’s that?”

“I was going to sleep with you.” She gave him a wide smile and a wink.

“Real funny.”

“Yeah, it is. Especially if I’m telling the truth and you accidentally traded it away for a poorly-cleaned bathroom.” Alice gave him another smile, this one far less festive and vastly more desirable. It came with softly tilted eyes and just a slight flush to her cheeks. Nick stumbled, his feet going stupid as his brain kicked into overdrive. By the time he recovered, Alice was cackling freely at his expense.

## 109.

Vince was sitting on a bench near the English building when a shadow fell across the open book in his lap. He didn't need to look up to know who it belonged to. He'd been sitting on this bench for at least an hour after classes all week long just to facilitate this meeting. It would have to happen eventually, and Vince wasn't one to put off things just because he wasn't looking forward to them.

"Want to sit?" Vince still didn't look up, even as he spoke. Eye contact would make everything feel closer, and a little mental distance would be good for both of them.

"Thank you," Chad said quietly. He took his position a few feet away from Vince. "I think I owe you an apology."

"I accept. Things got out of hand; I know you didn't mean to hurt anyone."

"I very much did not," Chad agreed.

"You're a good guy, Chad. You treat people with respect even though you're a lot stronger than most of them. Don't let one mistake overwhelm the whole of who you are. Trust me on this one."

Chad was tempted to ask for elaboration; however, he suspected Vince would have given some if he wanted to talk about it. "I shall try hard to keep that in mind."

"Good. You should probably apologize to Camille too. I mean, it was her party, after all."

"I made my amends with her this morning." Camille had been perfectly cordial when they spoke. Her two female friends on the other hand, they had been somewhat less willing to forgive. Chad suspected those two would bear a grudge against him for some time. He didn't blame them for it, either.

"I'm glad," Vince said. A shuffle of students meandered by the bench, forcing the two into temporary silence. This location wasn't ideal for private conversations - too many walkways left it exposed to frequent foot traffic. That was precisely why Vince had chosen this spot to wait. They were in full view of the regular students at all times. It was a measure to make sure neither

of them allowed their discussion to escalate into dangerous realms.

“So... about our fathers,” Chad said awkwardly once the other students had passed.

“Your father, and his former best friend,” Vince corrected. “I don’t think my father was that guy.”

“He had the watch.”

“Even if it’s the same watch there are still plenty of explanations. Maybe it was a gift from someone that recovered it, or maybe the Super who made them decided to craft some more. I don’t even know who this Globe person was, but I know my father. He wasn’t a Super, let alone a Hero. He was just a guy living the rails who took it upon himself to look after me.”

“Living the rails?”

“I wasn’t exactly anyone’s first choice for adoption as a child. I ran away from the foster system as soon as I could. He found me one night digging through a restaurant dumpster for food.” Vince’s eyes weren’t looking at his book anymore; they were staring beyond its starched white pages into an alley of the past, gazing at a silver-haired child gagging down rotten fruit because he was too hungry to pass it up. “Father took me in. He taught me how to live on the streets safely and with integrity. We never stole. We worked where we could and foraged whenever possible. Does that sound like a man hiding abilities to you?”

“Only if he were working very hard to hide them,” Chad admitted. “But it’s still not impossible.”

“I can turn this bench into cinders with a thought. You could lift that statue from across the lawn and throw it half a block past the end of campus. We have a very skewed sense of what is and isn’t impossible.”

“What’s your point?”

“I’ll probably never completely convince you that the man who raised me isn’t the same as the one who killed your dad,” Vince said slowly. “Not beyond any doubt. But I’ll never believe he did anything like that, either. So we have a homeless man with enough compassion to raise someone else’s freak of a kid until he dies in an explosion when I’m thirteen. If you prefer to think of him as a murdering former Hero in disguise then I can’t stop you; I can only tell you that there isn’t one shred of evidence in my memories to

support that theory.”

“I thought you said thirteen was the age he gave you the watch.”

“On my found-day. We didn’t know when I was born, so that was what we used to mark the passing of years. He died a few months later.”

“I’m sorry,” Chad replied. “Sincerely. Even if it was him, I’m sorry you had to lose your father.”

“Same to you,” Vince echoed.

“I think you’re right. I don’t know anything for sure. The watch is a damning piece of evidence, but it alone doesn’t prove anything. Globe’s body was never found; however, that doesn’t mean nothing of him survived.”

“Globe died?” Vince asked.

“His teammates killed him after he killed my father. Nick and Alice did a presentation on all of this last year for class.”

“I missed a few of them. Coach George called me into his office on one of the presentation days,” Vince explained.

Chad rifled through his memory. Sure enough, Vince had been yanked out that day. “You were gone for it. The summary is that Globe killed Intra, and then was killed off by the remainder of his team when he turned on them as well. Black Hole was the Hero who brought him down, and a side effect of his ability was that it didn’t leave a body behind, so some people have always wondered whether Globe was truly gone or not.” Chad didn’t mention how prominent a member of ‘some people’ he was. His actions over the past week already told that story too clearly.

“He sounds like a bastard.”

“Agreed.”

“I’m sorry he killed your dad.”

“Thank you.”

“Is that why you train so hard? Because you’re afraid someone will turn on you?”

Chad shook his head. “My father was one of the greatest Heroes who ever lived. He was strong, pure, and effective. Yet all anyone knows him for is being Globe’s victim. No one talks about the people he saved or the lives he

impacted. They only talk about the way he died.”

He stood up from the bench and stretched, feeling the shift of every muscle in his body as he re-centered them to perfect alignment.

“I intend to redeem my father’s abilities. I am going to show the world just how strong he really was, by showing everyone what these powers can do.” Chad turned and found Vince looking at him, the first meeting of one another’s eyes during their conversation. “I am going to become the strongest Hero this world has ever seen. I’ll surpass everyone, no matter what it takes.”

In that moment, watching the slow dip of the sun ring Chad’s blonde hair with orange light, Vince had no trouble believing him.

“I don’t think I’ll be in your way,” Vince said.

“We’ll see. If we ever do go against one another, it won’t be with any bad blood between us. I’m going to choose to believe you about your father.”

“I’m glad to hear it.” Vince slid the book to his side and stood up. He and Chad were nearly the same height, two taller-than-average fellows with much greater-than-average potential. He stuck out his hand, letting it jut into open air. “Friends?”

Chad accepted it and shook. “Allies.”

“Allies,” Vince agreed. “And, in next week’s match, competitors.”

“I look forward to it,” Chad said with a grin. Vince smiled right back. He was getting excited about the upcoming battle, too.

## 110.

Nick sat in the boys' lounge, pretending to read a book on statistics. The others would gather soon and he'd have to begin his strategy meeting. It was an event that would likely be unpleasant. They were going up against Chad's team, a proposition which meant that from the outset Nick knew he would have to throw a Hail Mary. It was a long shot, and while Nick was comfortable with the idea of high-risk high-reward scenarios, that didn't mean he was particularly looking forward to selling his team on it. Mary had been hard enough, and she had the sturdiest head on her shoulders out of the lot. Of course, that was only true because Nick had failed to account for another member of their team. Fortunately, that other team member had not forgotten to account for Nick.

"Nervous?"

Nick glanced up to see Hershel standing by the dart board. The hefty boy didn't move with much grace or speed, but he was unobtrusive enough to come and go without raising more than peripheral awareness.

"Me? Nah, I'm a wiz with numbers. This class won't know what hit it."

"You're not in a statistics class this semester," Hershel replied. "And even if you were, it's not like you need to study."

There was a gentle rustling of pages as Nick shut his book. "What makes you think I'm not in a statistics class?"

"Because you're not the only one who knows the value of listening when people talk." Hershel took a few steps forward and sank into a chair opposite of Nick. "You're also not the only one here with experience as a tactician."

"I see. So you've figured out our next move?"

"That's why I asked if you were nervous. Not going to be easy to convince those guys to go along with that sort of plan."

"Enlighten me. What plan have you assumed I formulated?"

"You want us to lose," Hershel said simply.

"Please elaborate."



“You want us to play defensively, not take risks, and do nothing more than run the clock on whatever trial they subject us to.”

“Okay,” Nick said. “Let’s presume you’re correct. I want us to give this match away. Why would I do that?” He leaned back in his chair a bit, giving Hershel more space to think. It turned out to be unneeded.

“Because you and I know both understand the gap between this team and Chad’s team. It’s a match that we can’t hope to win, regardless of the rules they give us.”

“We have the element of surprise,” Nick pointed out. “Alice’s new gravitational power is coming along at a steady rate, and Vince has successfully managed to absorb the kinetic energy of two tennis balls I’ve thrown at him.”

“Two out of how many?”

A small frown tugged at the corners of Nick’s mouth. “One hundred and thirty four.”

“I figured as much. If he was doing it reliably you would have asked Roy to join in the training. He could fill Vince with far more kinetic power than some tennis ball. That’s why you’re still on beginner exercises, and that’s also why you want us to lose. Right now we have two trump cards, two people who can do things no one else suspects. They’re still relatively new, however. If we blow them on a match we’re going to lose then we waste the chance to surprise another team.”

“So you think it’s better to let our hidden cards evolve into Aces before setting them on the table?”

“A child thinks only about the battle; a General considers the war as a whole. Losing this match covertly gives us a much better chance of winning our third one,” Hershel explained. “And I know you reached the same conclusion.”

“I won’t deny that. If the situation was as you described it then losing without giving our all truly would be the best idea. However, you’ve got a few facts incorrect,” Nick said. He inched forward toward the edge of his seat, reclaiming the space he had previously abandoned.

“I do?”

“Indeed. First off, we have three surprise cards, not two. Despite their

indignation at the loss, it seems Allen and Hector have stayed quiet about Camille's capacity for laying the hand-to-hand smack down. I've had Mary keeping mental tabs on them and neither has spilled the beans." Part of Nick would have liked to have discussed Camille's real power with Hershel, instead of the fighting skill they were pretending she had, however he didn't quite trust Roy to keep her secret.

"Why would they do that?"

"They wouldn't. They are worthless idiots. Britney, on the other hand, is a masterful competitor. She understands that now that they've lost to us there is nothing to gain by outing one of our member's talents. If that knowledge were to allow other teams to beat us, then it makes us appear weak, and them even weaker since we beat them. That girl grasps the simple truth that from here on out, the better we do, the better they seem for having come so close to victory."

"Enemy of my enemy..." Hershel said.

"Pretty much."

"Camille doesn't change much."

"Camille's fighting prowess does give us an unexpected advantage, in that no one realizes she's a capable warrior. That said, I agree that she alone wouldn't be enough to deviate from the plan of losing."

"So what else is there?"

"A few things: how hungry Alice is to prove her worth, for one, or the rate at which Vince's abilities accelerate in real combat for another. But all of them go toward a single issue that prevents us from giving up the match: feasibility of execution."

"You don't think they could do it?"

"I don't. You and I both know that even with your memories of how logical a choice it is, Roy would be a longshot for such a plan."

"He's not the one we have to worry about."

"Roy should always be worried about when constructing a plan. Especially when Chad is a factor. He has a soft spot for getting knocked senseless by that blonde adversary."

Hershel didn't have a comeback for that one; he merely nodded his

agreement.

“Besides, I could sooner charm the entire female population of the HCP into a massive orgy than I could talk Vince into giving up. There is not one single ounce of Quit in that boy, no matter how smart a choice it might be. Where he goes, Camille will follow, of course, and by the time three of us are fighting wholeheartedly, Alice won’t be able to hold back any longer. She’s been sidelined so much, now that she feels she can contribute she’d obviously jump in. That of course means Mary will break formation to go keep her friend safe, and by this point the only people still playing it smart are myself and Alex.”

“I think you underestimate how much they trust you. If you told them that was the plan, they’d go for it.”

“I assure you - they would agree to anything, and in the moment they would mean it. A person’s nature in combat is not easily changed, however. No, they would never give away a victory, regardless of the odds against them. Too bad, because you were right about it being the smart play,” Nick conceded.

“So if you can’t do the smart play, what’s left?”

“I should think that’s obvious,” Nick replied, a smarmy grin spreading across his face. “If you can’t make a smart play, you make a batshit crazy one.”

## 111.

“I’m pleased to see everyone looking so bright-eyed and bushy-tailed,” Professor Fletcher greeted. In truth, neither team was particularly befitting of either of those adjectives. This wasn’t due to any particular worry or case of the nerves: it was simply because all the super abilities in the world didn’t change the fact that college students hate being up early. Still, they’d accomplished their task of rousing and now stood in the gym with bleary but eager eyes.

“As you know, today is a match between your teams. I think we all understand what’s at stake, so I won’t waste any time telling you to try your best or any other such nonsense. Instead I’ll jump right into the rules. Today’s match will be a test of how you use the resources of your teammates over a prolonged time. We’re going to be going to the cells and doing some combat matches.”

Mary winced inwardly; everyone on Chad’s team except Will was either an experienced fighter or had an ability that would neutralize any skill brought against it. This was the system she’d been most afraid of.

“Of course, it wouldn’t be much of a test if we just randomly threw you all in fights, so instead you will be deciding the lineup,” Professor Fletcher continued. “Each team will take turns deciding who they want to send into the cell. The other team then gets to pick which member or members to send against them.”

The eyes of the students cleared as realization of his words dawned on them.

“You heard me right: you can send in multiple people to fight one person, or send in one person to fight multiple people. There are no rules on the match ups,” Professor Fletcher explained. He paused for a moment, savoring the attentive atmosphere before continuing. “However, each team member can only fight one time. So if you blow all seven members on the first match then you automatically lose the next six.” This time his pause was less about dramatics and more about giving them time to let it all sink in. Once a few brows had unfurled Professor Fletcher felt it was safe to move on.

“Standard HCP fight rules apply. The loser is the first one to pass out, give up, or be similarly incapacitated. Intentional lethal force will get you

disqualified. Any questions?”

“How do we decide who nominates a fighter first?” Chad asked immediately. It was a sound question; the team sending a person into the cell was at a disadvantage since their opponent got to pick their combat reactively. With seven people per team, that meant if no one used double members in a match then the first team to send someone into the cell would have four nomination matches and only three reaction matches.

“Well, normally we just flip a coin or something like that,” Professor Fletcher admitted. “That method is a little problematic, given the presence of Mr. Campbell.”

“Oh really? The one way I can actually help my team and we’re going to make it sound shameful?” Nick protested, his tone pleading and hurt.

“Strictly speaking, the only test of abilities here happens in the cells and in the decisions you make regarding them. Influencing the coin toss is technically cheating.”

“Then how about this?” Mary interjected. “Let’s just assume we’ll win whatever game of chance you play and say that Chad’s team is going to nominate first.”

“That is hardly-”

“But,” she interrupted, “my team promises to do a two-person nomination one time. If they do the same then it reduces the total matches to six, which means no one really gets an advantage.” This wasn’t entirely true, since Mary and Nick understood the value of striking a victory early on and how it could impact morale.

“I’ll agree to those terms,” Chad said. He knew the importance of a fearful first strike as well, but this was as good a situation as he could hope for against someone like Nick.

“I suppose that settles it then. Okay, Team Two, who would you like to send into the cell for the first match?” Professor Fletcher asked.

There was no discussion amidst the team, nor any need for it. Most of them were just as Mary had assessed: seasoned fighters. They knew that dominating an opponent early on often broke their spirit and left them unable to rally. It was a principle rule of war, and one that made their choice effortless.

“I’ll be first,” Chad declared.

“Very well. You and your team come with me to the observation room. I’ll leave Team One here to deliberate until I return,” Professor Fletcher said. He led Chad down the concrete halls, with Rich, Julia, Sasha, Will, Jill, and Selena trailing just a few steps behind. The team didn’t bother with chit-chat. They were friends, and when this was over they would talk and laugh and celebrate a victory or mourn a loss. That was later. In this moment, all each of them saw was the battle at hand. This shared trait, more than any particular ability, is what made Team Two such a monstrous combatant.

Chad was directed into a combat cell, one much like he’d been in back during his freshman trial. Of course he still used these for sparring and training - it was one of the only places people like him could really use all their strength - but the ones with observation rooms above them tended to be reserved for official events like this one. Chad’s eyes swept the room and took in the scant surroundings with a single glance. There were the usual microphone holes at the corner of one wall that allowed the PA system to be heard. Two walls opposite one another had long open slits at the top with a specially-reinforced clear material covering them. It was as easy to see through as glass, but given what that material could endure it was compositionally as far from actual glass as was possible. Chad did recognize that the presence of two viewing holes meant the teams would watch from separate rooms. It seemed this was a trial the HCP had used before.

He was bored with the room and went to go stand in its center. A lesser fighter would have weighed the merits of ambushing his opponent when they walked through the door. That seemed like it would be grounds for disqualification, when one considered the challenge. Besides, Chad enjoyed most of the people on Team One. He saw no reason not to treat this fight with honor. As he watched his own teammates fill into their observation room, Chad idly wondered who they would send against him. Mary was the obvious choice: last time he’d defeated her she’d been unable to see him. A visually fair fight might be more interesting. Roy would likely lobby for the right of challenge, too. That was fine; it had been months since their last match. Chad knew his sparring buddy couldn’t win, but he still took a bit of pride in watching him get stronger. It was possible Vince would want to try his luck. He and the absorber had never been in any kind of official battle. It would be an interesting, if predictable, fight. By the time the door finally opened, Chad had run through just about every opponent scenario possible. Except, of course, for the one that turned out to be correct.

“Hey there, big fella,” Nick said as he slid through the entrance and sealed the door behind him. “Looks like you and me are gonna tango.”

## 112.

“Did you get lost on the way to the observation room?”

Had the question come from almost anyone else Nick would have assumed a malicious intent. Given the genuine surprise and touch of concern on Chad’s face, it was evident he meant it sincerely.

“Fraid not. I’m the guy who gets to fight you.” Nick raised both of his hands in an exaggerated pugilistic stance, moving them up and down slowly while shifting his feet.

“That seems like a poor decision,” Chad observed. “You cannot hope to defeat me.”

“Oh yeah, no way that’s happening,” Nick agreed, dropping his fighting stance with a shrug. “You’ll definitely beat me. No contest.”

“So then why are you here?”

“Because you’d beat any of us,” Nick replied. “You are the unquestioned King of our class. No single person on my or anyone else’s team can stand against you in a one-on-one match. I’ll admit, a few of the others would put on a hell of a show, but luckily for me this isn’t a contest of awesome battle footage.”

“It’s a contest of resource management,” Chad said, comprehension dawning at last.

“And while a Two will lose to King no matter what game you play, the fact is that this loss still takes you out of the deck.”

“Beg pardon?”

“Sorry, my team uses an analogy of cards when measuring ourselves and our opponents. You’re the King because you’re the strongest in our class; I’m a Two because I’m the weakest. I trust you can see the humor in us opposing one another now.”

“Very clever,” Chad complimented. “Of course, this strategy would have been better used later in the contest. Now my team and I will incorporate your logic into our own plans.”

“It isn’t a perfect scheme,” Nick admitted. “But hey, you work with



what you've got."

"Students, are you ready to begin?" Professor Fletcher's voice boomed out from the wall, momentarily startling both students.

"I am," Nick said as soon as he recovered.

"Listen, I don't want to hurt you. Please surrender as soon as he starts us. Someone like you, without any physical abilities at all, well, even with my power of control it would be difficult to make sure I held back enough," Chad warned. "My ability doesn't alert me to the breaking points of your body."

Nick sighed inwardly. This guy would be running a great game of smack talk if he weren't so damned sincerely considerate. "You're right, that's probably the smart move."

Chad smiled with relief. "I'm ready," he called to the wall.

"Then this match has begun."

Chad stared at Nick, who looked right back at him through his sunglasses. For a few moments neither boy said or did anything. Eventually Chad's patience gave out. "Well?"

"Well what?"

"Aren't you going to quit?"

"Certainly not," Nick shot back with a grin.

"But it's the right call. You agreed with me that it was the right call."

"I agreed that it was the smart call," Nick corrected. "And unfortunately my team has already rejected the smart method of dealing with this situation. Thus I am forced to decline your kind suggestion. Come at me whenever you're ready."

Chad laughed in spite of himself. "I wish you did have a power to fight me with. Someone with your guts could have made a great opponent."

"No argument here."

Chad's small burst of laughter subsided and his calm of battle cascaded over him. It was a shame: beating up someone like Nick made him feel like a bully. Too bad, this was a match; there was no room for soft-hearted empathy. The kindest thing he could do was end it fast and efficiently, injuring his opponent as minimally as possible. In the blink of eye Chad was

rocketing forward, closing the half-room gap between he and Nick in less than a few seconds. It wasn't super speed, but it was coordination and acceleration that no human could hope to match. Chad threw his hand out to grab Nick's arm and start a submission hold... but his hand closed around air. An abrupt stop and turn revealed the sunglasses-clad boy standing a few feet from where Chad had attacked. Not a vast difference, but a noticeable one. Chad didn't make those kind of mistakes.

He narrowed his eyes and increased his brain's level of perception. The world around him seemed to slow as his neurons began firing faster and faster. Mental overclocking too much was dangerous, even for someone with his power. If he accidentally damaged his brain, he wouldn't be able to focus enough to fix it. Still, he was well below the limit of how high his perception could rise. He hurled himself forward, a hot knife through a world stuck in molasses.

This time he saw what happened, and he understood how he'd missed it earlier. Nick waited until the very last moment of Chad's charge, when it seemed like he was inescapably caught, before turning his entire body on his heel at a precise angle and shifting away. It was similar to the technique used on rushing bulls, though because of Chad's speed, Nick had to be hundreds of times more exact when he spun. For someone without a physical power it should have been impossible.

"How did you do that?" Chad brought his body to a halt and let his mind come back to regular speed.

"What can I say? I've always understood the importance of good timing."

"Seriously. I move much too fast for any untrained guy to just step out of the way."

"First off, I've been in HCP for a year and a half, too. I might not be lifting cars or punching invincible people, but I did pick up some training here and there."

"Not that much," Chad accused.

"Secondly, it's not like I'm not banking on a little luck with my movements," Nick replied.

"Luck doesn't matter in a fight."

“Luck matters in everything.”

“No, it doesn’t. Knowing when to dodge requires judgment, timing, and experience. Luck could never compensate for all of that.”

“It could, if it was all I was using.” Nick reached up and gently plucked his trademark sunglasses off of his face. Chad was curious to see what the always hidden eyes looked like, but in that regard he was disappointed. Nick’s eyes were firmly shut, not a speck of light going out or getting in.

“You were fighting me with your eyes closed?”

“No wonder Roy says you’re so smart. Got it on the first try.”

Chad felt something bubbling in the pit of his stomach, an unpleasantly hot sensation. Had he been more emotionally actualized he would have understood it was anger and hurt pride at Nick’s taunting words. Chad wasn’t self-aware enough to realize that, but he was far enough along to understand he wanted to end this fight. His brain sped back up as Nick put his sunglasses on. It was time to get serious.

This time Chad didn’t just barrel forward, he did a controlled charged that slowed once he got near Nick. The sandy-haired boy tried to pedal backwards, but once he was in range, Chad could easily stop the distance between them from widening. Even at this range, however, Nick kept nimbly slipping away. He twisted, folded, ducked, bent, and slid at just the right moment every time.

“You can’t keep this up forever,” Chad spat through gritted teeth.

“Oh, definitely. I don’t have your stamina. In fact, I doubt I can last another minute,” Nick agreed.

Chad didn’t have the patience to wait that minute. He brought his perception up by several more degrees, far more than he ever should have needed against someone like Nick, and let fly a flurry of attacks. This time even Nick’s luck couldn’t save him: his arm was ensnared by Chad’s powerful hand. After that, it was a matter of seconds before he was bent to the ground, Chad trying hard not to accidentally break his arm while keeping the submission hold.

“You win,” Nick said immediately. “I give up.”

“The winner of the first match is Chad Taylor of Team Two,”

Professor Fletcher's voice boomed from the wall.

Chad released his adversary and offered him a hand up. Nick took it gratefully; his own arm felt a bit wonky despite Chad's evident restraint.

"Why in the hell didn't you just do that in the first place?" Chad asked.

"You know, there are a lot of bullshit reasons I could feed you right now. I could say it's because I like challenging strong opponents who make me grow, or because I had too much pride to give up without being properly beaten. Stuff like that, stuff I'm sure you'd swallow without hesitation. But I like you; not many people with your kind of power are decent enough to also respect those weaker than they. So just this once I'm going to do something out of character and tell you the truth. I did it to steal your overwhelming victory."

"But you lost."

"And you won. What you didn't do was crush me, or anyone else on my team. You didn't manage to demoralize us like you were hoping."

"That more seems like you negated it than you stole it," Chad pointed out.

"A King will always beat a Two," Nick said. "It almost doesn't matter what game you play. But it's a given; no one expects any different."

"I'm missing your point."

Nick stopped walking toward the door and stared at Chad. Despite the sunglasses, Chad could feel Nick's eyes boring into him. "A King will always beat a Two. The difference between them is so great that it should be as effortless as killing a bug. You beat me, there's no question about that. But you didn't do it all that easily. What my team, and yours, just saw was a Two managing to keep pace with a King. They just saw the weakest member of the HCP force the strongest to really work for an unsatisfying victory. Now you tell me, do you think something that impossible has my team feeling particularly demoralized? Or do you think it made them believe that if lowly little old me can do something so impossible that we might have a real shot at winning this thing?"

Chad took a moment before speaking. "You are much more dangerous than I expected."

Nick smiled and began walking again. “This is only the first match. Wait til you see what I do with the others.”

## 113.

“That was incredible!” Vince bounded forward to clap Nick on the back as he entered the room. The others weren’t far behind, offering similar tidings of congratulations. Nick wasn’t sure whether it said more about how strong everyone thought Chad was or how weak they viewed him to be that merely not getting annihilated drew such a reaction. Given that it was what he’d been banking on, however, he supposed either one was acceptable.

“I still can’t believe you dodged him by closing your eyes,” Alice muttered.

“Trust me, no one is more surprised that worked than me, with the possible exception of Chad,” Nick replied humbly. “I take it you folks overheard our little adversarial chat?”

“No, Mary gave us a sort of narration based on your thoughts and what you were doing,” Alex explained. “Unless you’re hooked up to the mike and speaker system those cells are completely soundproof.”

Nick stepped away from the crowd and looked through the relatively thin slit that comprised their window. Across the cell he could see into the other team’s prep room; they were huddling together and congratulating Chad. The blonde captain didn’t look as sure of himself as he should be after a win. A warm glow of satisfaction cascaded through Nick’s mind. He’d successfully planted the seeds of uncertainty; now he had to capitalize on them.

“Chad is the one making all the decisions,” Mary said, sidling up next to him and lowering her voice. “They figured out that strategy before he was done with the fight. Since I can’t read his mind, we’re going to be working as blind as they are.”

“Not entirely. We still know who they are on a personal level. Telepathy is well and good, but I’ve been predicting people’s actions long before I had access to a mind reader.”

“I take that to mean you’ve come up with a plan?”

“You know me so well. It’s going to get very rough. Can you keep them together?”

“Find a way to keep us in this thing, I’ll make sure they keep at it.”

“Let’s hope so, because this next one will be bad,” Nick warned. “Hey, Camille!”

The small girl turned and looked at the pair curiously. “Yes? Do you need some healing?”

“Nah, not right now. You have more important things to deal with. Mary and I talked it over and decided you’re our pick for the next round.” Nick took advantage of the stunned silence that followed to shift his position and brace himself. There was a good chance he really might need some healing before Camille was out of the room.

“What?!” Vince blurted as realization finally struck home. “You’re pairing her with someone, right? That’s why we agreed to do a two-person round, so we could couple a strong offense with Camille’s healing ability.”

“Vince is right; that girl has no place being in the cell by herself,” Roy echoed. “You’re one thing, but she could get really hurt.”

“And if the healer gets injured then who helps her?” Alex tacked on.

Mary held up a hand to silence them, and surprisingly they complied with minimal grumbling. “I hear your concerns, I really do. But Nick made a compelling case, so hear him out before you decide he’s wrong.” Mary turned, ready to actually hear the case she’d pretended to know and endorse.

“We’re probably going to lose this event,” Nick said, his face unusually straightforward. “I told you all that from the beginning. Even in this format we’re at a disadvantage. I’ve run through the lineup combinations in my head dozens of times, and in the vast majority we lose four out of six matches. There are a couple - a very slender few – of exceptions. The only arrangement of those we have any reasonable shot at still requires a very precise order of execution, which is remarkably harder, given that our opponents get to choose their participant in three of the matches. I think I can get us there, but only if you all trust me and go in the order Mary and I decide.”

“I’ll go,” Camille said, so softly that it would have been inaudible had the room not been stricken silent.

“You don’t have to do that,” Vince told her.

“She does if we want a shot at this thing,” Nick rebutted. Vince threw his friend a look dirtier than Nick would have believed him capable of

conjuring.

“I’m doing it,” Camille insisted. “I’m not at this school just to heal everyone else, you know. I’m here to learn, and to fight, and to get stronger. I’m here to become a Hero, and Heroes don’t have the luxury of sitting out a fight just because it’s hard.”

“But-”

“We’re done talking about this.” Camille turned toward Nick, less because she actually wanted to speak to him and more because she couldn’t bear the look of worry on Vince’s face. “Anything I need to know?”

“I’m betting you have the same guess as me on who they’ll send against you, right?”

Camille nodded. No matter what they were planning, some opportunities were too rare to pass up. She knew who would be gunning for her.

“Then I’ll just say this: I don’t support pyrrhic victories as a rule, but on this occasion I think there might be a bit of value to the concept,” Nick instructed, his eyes scouring Camille’s face for any signs of comprehension. The small girl was smarter than most of the others; he could only hope she knew what he was talking about. Her lashes went up and she let out a quick breath. He wasn’t entirely sure what that meant, but he’d given as much as he could with this many people in earshot.

“Good advice,” Camille said without commitment. She turned and walked out the door, leaving behind a rising babble of voices as she exited. She could already hear them badgering Nick for more information, but she doubted he would give anything up. That boy was disturbingly clever.

Camille could see the surprise ripple through the opponents’ room as she entered the cell. Whatever they’d been expecting, it wasn’t her. That was the whole point, after all. This match’s strategy was insanity: keep the others off-balance and make it impossible for them to predict what Team One would do next. So far, so good. She hoped.

It didn’t take long for the cell door to open again. Camille considered feigning surprise then thought better of it. This was a rare opportunity for them to face one another plainly, with all feelings and thoughts laid bare. She wouldn’t be the one to sully it with cheap ploys.



“Good morning, Sasha. Thanks for not keeping me waiting.”

“The least I could do,” Sasha replied. “After all, if there’s one thing someone with my ability should be, it’s punctual.”

## 114.

Camille had never fought someone with super speed before. She'd expected the fast movements, obviously, and she knew enough about them to be aware that Sasha would be more resistant to injury than most. What Camille hadn't anticipated was how hard her opponent could hit, which was unfortunate.

"Ooof." Camille let out a guttural gasp as Sasha's fist buried itself in her diaphragm. Before she had any semblance of a chance to recover, a quick jab to the cranium sent her tumbling to the floor. A punch like that should have at least cracked her attacker's hand bones, but as she stared up at Sasha, it was clear the girl with pink-streaked hair had barely even felt it. Bitch.

"I have to say, I was expecting a little more," Sasha chided. "I mean, I know you're just a healer, but I would have thought all that time in Close Combat would have taught you a few tricks."

Camille sucked in a slow breath that made her ribs ache. She'd hit the floor hard enough to bruise them, but she was pretty sure nothing was broken. Her head was largely okay; thankfully, Sasha had struck the densest part. Slowly, she staggered to her feet. These injuries would be nothing to heal, take almost no effort at all. That would work against her, unfortunately, and Camille was determined to strike her own version of victory.

"That why they sent down a heavy hitter? I have to say I'm surprised Chad was willing to squander such a strong fighter on little old me."

"I convinced him. Captain or not, he understands the need to work out personal grudges with one's fists."

"So it's a grudge now?"

"Not really," Sasha replied. She flashed forward, moving too quickly for Camille to react, and swept the smaller girl's legs while pushing back on her head. Camille was able to shift her weight mid-air to avoid a headfirst impact, but as she crunched to the ground, she knew something in her shoulder had broken. "I just thought we ought to have some girl-talk time."

"How... sweet." Camille barely got the words out as pain rippled through her. Either by mercy or sadism, Sasha backed off and allowed her to struggle to her feet once more. "I can only imagine what you'd do to someone

who was actually dating your ex.”

“I don’t think it’s an issue we’ll have to deal with soon. I’ve already decided I want him back.”

“No? And here I thought you were kicking my ass for the cardio.” It was funny; for the first time she could remember, Camille wasn’t feeling self-conscious about her words. Maybe it was the pain, or maybe it was just a side effect of real battle. Either way, she found herself staring back at Sasha without any sense of shyness whatsoever. If anything, she wanted to confront her all the more. “Of course, that’s if he takes you back.”

“Don’t kid yourself, honey. You might have that damsel in distress thing that he eats up, but you could never be real competition for me.” To illustrate the point, Sasha closed the gap between them and delivered a series of quick blows to Camille’s torso. The small girl stayed standing longer than anyone would have expected, but a punch that shattered one of her ribs finally sent her back to the floor in a coughing fit of pain.

\* \* \*

“I can’t believe you did this to her.” Vince’s hands were gripped into fists, the tips of his fingers turning white as they pressed tightly against the flesh of his palm. Had it been anyone else, Nick would have been truly concerned that he might swing at him. Since it was Vince, Nick was only moderately worried.

“Did this to her? The other team picked the opponent, you know.”

“But you’re the one who sent her out there alone!” Vince turned away from the fight to jab his best friend in the shoulder, eyes blazing with accusation. Nick stared right back at him, the cool glass covering his eyes a sharp contrast to fiery rage echoing through his friend’s.

“Do you realize how fucking condescending you sound when you say things like that?”

Vince was momentarily taken aback; he hadn’t expected Nick to go on the offensive. Nick took the opportunity to press on.

“Camille is not some puppy or flower to be watched over. She said it herself, she’s training to be a Hero. You think that path is paved with rainbows? It’s built on pain, sweat, and failure. Getting your ass kicked is part of this process. She knows it, I know it, and when it applies to anyone but

females you know it too. Stop treating that girl with deference and treat her with the respect that a fellow warrior deserves.”

Vince glowered, but the wind had been plundered from his sails. Nick was right: Vince hadn’t objected when he volunteered to go up against Chad. He’d had faith his friend could handle whatever happened. It was wrong to put any less confidence in Camille. Nonetheless, as he turned back to what could barely be called a fight, Vince felt his hands tighten again. He had to watch her, he just didn’t have to like it.

\* \* \*

Camille hacked up a phlegmy wad of blood before staggering to her feet. She was visibly swaying now; one of Sasha’s many attacks had probably injured her inner ear. The fight had been going on for only two minutes, but Camille felt like she was already at her breaking point. She had to end this, and soon.

“I’m impressed you keep getting up, even if I’m not sure what you’re expecting to accomplish,” Sasha complimented.

“Of course not. You wouldn’t understand why I can’t just lay down and lose. People like you have never been weak, or bullied. You’ve spent your whole life able to outrun or barrel through any problem.”

“You say that like it’s a bad thing.”

“Not for you, I guess. But there are lessons that come from being knocked down, the most important of which is learning how to get back up.” Camille spat a pink loogie to the ground, her mouth still leaking blood that was beginning to coat her teeth. “That’s why you don’t deserve to be with Vince. Things got tough and you ran away.”

“He lied to me.”

“Boo fucking hoo. You made him feel like shit and broke his heart. He got through it, though, because Vince is more like me than you. He’s been weak. He’s been battered. He always gets back up. And so will I. So do your worst, bitch. It won’t change the fact that you blew it with the best man, hell, the best person, either of us will ever meet.”

The words were barely out of her mouth before Sasha’s punch collided with her teeth. This time the super-speed girl didn’t stop when Camille went down; instead she kept pressing the attack, smashing her opponent’s face and

body over and over again.

“Enough,” Professor Fletcher’s voice blared through the room. “The winner of this match is Sasha Foster.”

“Hear that?” Sasha said, still clutching the small girl’s jacket collar in her hand. “I won.”

Camille looked back at her, then past her, to something over Sasha’s shoulder. Despite her face being coated in blood, a smile was still visible on Camille’s busted lips.

“Did you?”

Sasha turned to follow Camille’s gaze. What stared back at her was Vince, watching from the team room with an expression Sasha had never seen on his face before: horror. Horror mixed with disgust. All of it aimed directly at her.

Camille saw realization dawn across her opponent’s face and felt a soft glow of accomplishment. It was her last sensation for some time, as the pain finally caught up to her and she slipped into sweet unconsciousness.

## 115.

There was a small break before the next match while Professor Fletcher delivered Camille to the infirmary for healing. Both teams were locked in their room, ostensibly so that neither could receive outside influence. In reality it was a precaution to stop them from going at it without supervision. So far everyone had kept their cool, but Professor Fletcher knew that watching a teammate get pummeled could provoke some unexpected reactions. By the time he returned and was ready to resume the competition, Team Two had already selected Will as their nominee.

He was only in the cell for a few seconds before Alex entered, giving an awkward wave of greeting to his friend.

“Let’s not try and imitate them, if possible,” Will said in lieu of a hello.

“Agreed. I think both of us are smart enough to know when to call it quits.”

“True. Then again, I would have said the same for Camille.” Will was working hard to keep his emotions in check. Rooming with Thomas, Stella, and Violet meant Camille was a frequent guest in his home. In spite of being on different teams, he had taken no joy in watching Sasha administer such a ruthless beating. Not for the first time he found himself a bit thankful that his ability didn’t require getting too up close and personal with a foe.

“She’s a strange one,” Alex said. “Most of the time I can feel her terror from yards away. But when things get truly scary, that’s when she practically explodes with fearless determination.”

“We’ll all go visit her in the infirmary when this is done.”

“Good idea.”

“Students, are you ready to begin?” The voice crackled from the PA, and both boys nodded their agreement rather than respond verbally. “Then this match has begun.”

Alex struck first, telekinetically smashing Will back into the wall. He then pinned his opponent to the ground under a sustained blast of force. Will might have all manner of technology at his disposal, but Alex had no intention of giving him a chance to use it.

“You’re trying to make me surrender,” Will grunted from under the invisible bulk pressing upon him.

“As painlessly as possible,” Alex confirmed. He didn’t want to hurt Will, but his team couldn’t take many more losses. One more and all they could do was tie. Two more and it was done.

“Good plan,” Will complimented. “Unfortunately, you got the wrong opponent.” Will made a sort of clicking noise against his teeth, hammering out a strange sequence of notes. Alex’s vision blurred and his concentration disintegrated as the room filled with a high-pitched squeal. The floor seemed to be trembling as Alex fell to his knees and pressed his hands over his ears.

“Sonic taser,” Will explained as he pulled himself to his feet. He tapped a small device on his belt that had a small LED light glowing green. “I installed a verbal switch for just such an occasion. Good thing I did, too. Otherwise you would have trounced me.”

Alex was shaking now; he felt like his bones were going to vibrate out of his skin. It took almost more than he had just to mumble a strained, “How?”

“If you’re wondering how you can hear me, it’s because the sound isn’t actually that loud. It’s merely precisely calibrated to attack various parts of the inner ear. If you’re asking how I can stay unaffected, it’s because I put dampeners in my own ears before I ever came to the cell. You really should give up, by the way. While this shouldn’t do any damage that can’t be healed, the effects will continue to get worse the longer you are exposed.”

He was telling the truth. Alex could barely handle being on his knees anymore. Much longer and he would collapse to the floor in a curled up ball. That would mean losing, and they’d already given up two fights. Alex could feel the weight of the others’ gazes, their hopes resting squarely on his shoulders. He had one shot to turn this around; the only question was if he could manage enough concentration to pull it off. Alex forced himself to take slow, deep breaths. It wasn’t easy: each gasp was like swallowing magma as the sound seemed to shred across his lungs. He kept going. This was what he had trained for. This was what separated people with powers from Heroes.

The only one more surprised than Will when Alex began to rise from the floor was Alex himself. He’d practiced this technique a few times in private; however, this was the first real trial it was getting. His body began to settle down, though he’d likely need a session with a healer before he was

truly back to normal.

“How...” This time it was Will’s turn to ask a question in shock. His confusion only grew at the crunching sounds from his waist. His sonic taser fell to the ground uselessly, its final death note briefly ringing across the concrete interior before sputtering out completely. Will felt himself slammed to the ground once more, but this time the mental weight was so heavy he had to make an effort to breathe.

“You said it was unfortunate I got you as an opponent; well, I can say the same right back to you,” Alex declared. “I spent almost a year dating a girl who can enchant people with her song. That sort of thing got me wondering if there was a way to negate that type of ability. I figured that if I could reflect all the sound waves coming at me then that might do it. It’s really hard; I’d never have thought I could pull it off in actual combat.”

“But... telekinetics... can only... touch things... that are solid,” Will wheezed out from the ground.

“Good thing I’m not telekinetic then. So, how long do I have to keep you pinned before you do like we promised?”

Will’s excellent mind raced through a myriad of options. He still had a few gizmos that could turn things around, but none of them could be reached or aimed while he was pinned. Besides, if Alex really could knock aside something as intangible as a sound wave, Will wasn’t sure anything in his arsenal would be able to connect. No, there was only one logical conclusion to reach, and Will Murray was a logical man.

“I... concede.”

“The winner of this match is Alex Griffen,” Professor Fletcher said, making the first victory of Team One official.

Alex released the pinning pressure and helped his friend up from the ground. “Sorry I broke your thingie.”

“A risk of bringing tools into battle,” Will replied. “Besides, it gives me the chance to make some improvements.”

The two shook hands and departed, leaving the cell waiting for its next set of competitors.



“Thank you, sweet heaven,” Nick mumbled as he watched Alex and Will leave the cell.

“Feeling worried?” Alice asked. The others had drifted off to greet Alex at his triumphant return, but she had remained by Nick as he stared into the now empty space.

“I was feeling screwed. For a moment there I thought all was lost.”

“Don’t be so dramatic. We could have still pulled off a tie.”

Nick shook his head. “If they’d gotten that match they would have shifted strategy. Played it more conservatively until they got the next win they needed. We could have gotten maybe one win out of it all, if that. Now they don’t have that lock yet. Chad will play aggressively, trying to win rather than trying to last.”

“How can you know that?”

“Because Chad’s a winner in charge of a team of winners. They’re chasing victory because they’re used to capturing it.”

Alice chuckled lightly. “So that makes us a team of losers?”

“I prefer to think of it as a team of people who have had ample opportunity to build character through adversity.”

“Classy,” Alice complimented.

Mary meandered over and glanced at the two of them. Although she felt a bit guilty interrupting given the way Alice’s brain was tingling with cheer, there was business to attend to.

“One win is good, now who do we send out to get another?” Mary asked.

“I’m thinking the two lovely ladies in front of me,” Nick replied.

Mary and Alice exchanged an uncertain glance.

“Oh, don’t give me that,” Nick continued. “We said we’d do a duo in one of our rounds. This is the time for it.”

“I don’t disagree with you there, but why us?” Alice asked.

“Subterfuge,” Nick said. “Mary, can you do what Alex just did? Hold someone down without seriously injuring them?”

“Not unless they’ve got enhanced endurance like Roy or Chad. I’m a little too strong for it otherwise, and Alex has better fine control than I do.”

“Exactly.”

“Exactly what?”

“Exactly; you can’t use Alex’s technique. I know it, you know it, and now Alice knows it. Guess who doesn’t know it? Chad’s team. Alice, our little gravity guru, could probably replicate it so well that no one would be able to tell the difference. Not unless they’d experienced both - but thankfully Will is unable to make a return performance.”

“Oh, you son of a bitch. You want me to keep acting helpless, even after I’ve worked my ass off to finally contribute to this team,” Alice accused.

“You’ll be contributing a great deal. You just won’t get credit for it, except from us.”

“These aren’t just contests for fun, you know. We each get evaluated, win or lose: everything we do goes toward whether or not we make the cut for next year. I’m not against helping the team, but I haven’t had a great showing so far. Now that I can do more than float about uselessly this is my chance to step things up.”

“Alice, not once in any of my plans, tactics, or strategies have I considered you as useless.” Nick could have sold it with an emphatic addition of counterfeit sincerity, but Alice would have immediately prickled with distrust. Instead he spoke in his usual manner, making no effort to seem more genuine. Ironically, this was as close as he could get to real sincerity.

“Sure, like I’d believe that. You gave me a four, remember?”

“You’re the one who found the flag and won our last team match,” Mary pointed out. “Not to mention that without you they couldn’t have rescued me from Coach George. Nick is telling the truth; the only person who ever thought you were useless was you.”

“Look, we’re on a limited amount of time, so I’ll leave it up to you two,” Nick interjected. “All I can say is that I promise you’ll get a chance to

shine before the year is over, and it will be all the brighter because no one will be expecting it. If you're really worried about making the cut then I can't argue with putting on a show today. Just make sure you're doing it because you want to be here next year and not out of a desire to make everyone respect your abilities."

Alice nodded silently; her mind was already digesting Nick's words. No one else on the team could have made her pause. None of the others understood what it was like to stand idly by while you watched your friends do amazing things. Only Nick could know how she felt; after all, he might have given her a four but he gave himself a two. She wanted to go into that cell and tear things up for a change. She just didn't know if it was for her team or her ego.

"We need to head down," Mary said, snapping her out of reverie.

"Let's go," Alice replied. They turned and headed toward the door, only now realizing that the rest of the room had fallen silent during their discussion. Soft words of encouragement were spoken, but most of their friends stood back as the duo moved closer to the exit.

"Hey, Alice," Nick called as the girls reached the door.

"Yeah?"

"If you win, I'll clean your bathroom."

Alice smiled in spite of herself. The boy had a talent for lightening moods, no one could dispute that.

"Screw that. If I win I want something better."

"Like what?"

"You have to answer one question with complete honesty."

Nick paused for a half of a heartbeat. "Deal," he said. Alice liked that pause; it meant he'd had to think about it. It meant he might even keep his word. She and Mary resumed their walk. It wasn't until they were in the cell that Mary spoke, and when she did her tone was filled with mock annoyance.

"You know, you might have asked me before turning down the cleaning offer. I bet we could have gotten him to at least throw in the girls' lounge."

## 117.

Julia and Jill stared at Mary and Alice from across the room. Unlike the previous fights, this one wasn't beginning with anything more than a cursory greeting as they waited for permission to start. All four girls were on pleasant enough terms, though Mary and Alice tended to see more of Jill than Julia, especially after the cessation of her and Roy's carnal acrobatics. They liked each other and in a pinch would probably sit at the same table in a lunch room should they spot an open seat. It wasn't devout friendship, only amiable enjoyment. And now they had to beat the hell out of one another. No one knew exactly what to say in that sort of situation, so they'd defaulted to nothing. It was what worked best for everyone.

"Are you ready to begin?" All four girls visibly relaxed at the sound of Professor Fletcher's voice. Horrible as battle might be, it was still preferable to standing around anticipating the carnage.

"We're ready," Mary replied confidently.

"As are we," Julia added.

"Then this match has begun."

The sound had barely subsided from the loudspeaker when everyone leapt into action. Julia produced four clones in the span of a second, all of them charging at Alice. Jill activated an electrical blaster bracer worn around her forearm and lined up a shot on Mary. Mary slammed a blast of telekinetic force into the stampeding Julias, scattering them like blonde bowling pins back toward their creator. Alice hopped into the air and tried to look like she were merely terrified while in truth she was focusing on increasing the gravity around her opponents. She managed to pull it off and only barely in time. The sudden increase of force dropped Julia to the ground but only took Jill to her knees. It was enough to make her shot go wild; a crackling ball of energy crashed to the concrete only a few feet away from Mary's vulnerable form.

"Damn," Jill swore from under her helmet as she struggled to pull herself up. The only thing keeping her in this fight was her patchwork suit's muscle enhancers valiantly straining to stop her from becoming effectively pinned. She said a mental prayer of thanks to Will; if he hadn't augmented them last month, there was no way she could have handled this level of strain. Julia was useless in this situation: any clones she produced were just as

powerless as her original form. What Jill, mistakenly, believed to be Mary's technique was exceptionally effective. She'd known battling the small girl would be tough but had hoped Alice's uselessness would give them a two on one advantage.

"You're beaten," Mary said in a matter-of-fact tone. She wasn't trying to taunt or goad her opponents; she was only conveying what she saw as the truth of the matter. Jill was having a hard time disagreeing with her, too. The girl in the gizmo suit slowly raised her right arm, trying to line it up for another shot. If Mary was using her power to push them down, then she might not be able to dodge, at least not without letting up on the assault some.

Jill succeeded in getting her arm halfway up before the intensity of the force knocking her downward increased. Suddenly it was too much, and the delicate balance she'd managed to retain was shattered. Jill tumbled to the floor, and no amount of straining would allow her to lift a limb. The most she could hope for was to fire off a few rounds and pray one ricocheted into Mary. For a brief moment she contemplated it then decided otherwise. No one in the other teams knew that Will had found a way to make her blasts bounce off inanimate objects yet. She didn't want to squander a surprise like that on a battle that was pretty much already lost anyway. Years later, when looking back at this particular match and understanding what had truly been going on, Jill would appreciate the humor of that train of thought. In the actual moment, there was only one thing she could really do.

"I give up," Jill acknowledged.

"Guess that means I do too," Julia huffed out from the floor. She had merely been holding out in case Jill came up with a way to turn things around. The clones dissolved back into formless energy, leaving only the two real girls still stuck on the floor.

"The winners of this match are Mary Smith and Alice Adair."

Alice floated down and grabbed Mary in a big hug. Jill and Julia felt the force binding them vanish, and both slowly rose to their feet.

"I'd say good fight, but it would feel like a lie," Jill admitted to the victors. "We went down without much of a showing at all. Nice technique, by the way."

"If Alex hadn't given me the idea, this might have been a very different outcome," Mary lied graciously. "Striking first was the only way we had a shot. That blaster of yours seems pretty nasty."

“It gets the job done. I have to say, your team has done surprisingly well today.”

“You’ve also done well, but it’s not really a surprise.”

“Tell me about it,” Julia mumbled. “I’m just annoyed I had to be on the sacrificial team.”

“The what?” Alice asked.

“She means we were picked because Chad knew we would lose,” Jill explained.

“I see; he took Nick’s lesson to heart then,” Mary noted.

“That he did. So, like I said, good job so far today. It’s almost too bad you’ve got no way to win the next two matches.” Jill headed out the door after making sure Julia was close by.

Mary and Alice waited a few moments before following suit, taking a different path once they’d left the cell, one that led back to their own observation room.

“Do you think she’s right?”

“There are two people left on Chad’s team: Selena and Rich. Both use an ability that renders their opponent unable to fight back. What we’ve got left is Vince and Roy, both of whom rely on physical abilities to defeat anyone they face,” Mary surmised.

“So, we’re screwed?”

“It sure looks that way.”

“Good,” Alice said, a wicked smile curving across her pleasant face. “If it looks like we’ve got no chance of winning that just means we’re exactly where Nick wants us to be.”

“Unquestionably. Now we just have to hope he’s as smart as he thinks he is.”

“Ooooooh. If we’re banking on that then we really might be screwed.”

The girls were still laughing about that little joke by the time they made it back to the room.

Selena didn't have to wait long for Vince to enter the cell. She was a little surprised: when Chad had nominated her, she'd been certain they'd send down Roy and hope his ability would let him resist her song. It wouldn't, of course; Selena had tested herself against those like Roy before she'd even hit her teens. They might be able to walk away from a speeding car crash without a scrape, but it did them no good once Selena Wilkins had them under her spell.

Vince looked determined as he moved carefully to the opposite side of the cell. She waved a hand to greet him, and he returned the gesture. Selena avoided speaking before battles so no one could accuse her of using her power before things officially kicked off. Vince's reason for silence was much simpler than that: he merely couldn't think of what to say. He knew he had to win, he knew his team was counting on him, and at the same time he wasn't sure how he was going to do any of it. Selena's considerable abilities aside, she was physically a normal girl. Stronger and leaner than most her age, but still quite vulnerable by HCP standards. At least Camille was in Close Combat training. Beating up Selena would leave a sick taste in Vince's mouth, and that was assuming he could even find a way to do it. He had one idea; however, even he knew it was something of a long shot.

"Are you ready to begin?"

"I am," Vince said immediately. A long shot was better than no shot. He narrowed his eyes and focused with all he had. No matter which way it went, this fight would be over in less than a minute.

"I'm ready." Selena's vibrant voice was devoid of melody, yet it still held an almost musical quality. Vince wasn't the only one poised for action. Her tongue darted briefly across her lips, a sign of nervousness and a preparation for the impending musical onslaught all rolled into one almost imperceptible motion.

"Then this match has begun."

Selena threw herself to the side at the same time she allowed a thick, hearty series of notes to burst forth. To her surprise, she dodged nothing, as the fireball she'd been certain Vince was aiming at her never materialized. The tan girl rolled to her feet, song continuing to flow without so much as a

pause, and looked at her opponent, who seemed frozen in place. Vince hadn't so much as twitched since the battle began; he was still clearly standing in the same spot, not even looking at her.

Selena shook her head. No, he wasn't clear, not clear at all. In fact, the longer she stared at him, the more distorted he appeared to be, like someone had secretly drawn a wall of water between the two of them and was agitating it more and more with every passing moment. She figured it out almost a full two seconds before the heat struck her.

The massive outpouring of thermal energy washed over her like a blanket made of lava. It burned at her eyes and grabbed at her nostrils. She didn't immediately blister, but she had a feeling prolonged exposure to this environment would cook her from the inside out. Still, she kept singing, her rich lullaby cascading across the acoustically-ideal concrete walls, permeating Vince's ears even as his endless heat scorched across her skin. She could barely make out his form anymore; the distortion of the air and the tears in her eyes were teaming together to make seeing a cause at the edge of hopelessness.

Selena's throat felt seared as she gasped for a breath. The air was thin and sizzled in her lungs. Had she been anyone else, the spasms wracking her chest would have become full-fledged coughs and all would have been lost. Her mind was a fog of pain, her tongue felt as if it had matches underneath it, but she knew she was still singing. The burning in her throat told her that even more clearly than the gorgeous notes still ringing in her ears. This was her last breath; the next one would be more than she could bear. Selena poured every bit of herself into her song, every thought, every sense, every emotion. It was a melody of peace, a song of slumber, and right now there was almost nothing in the world she wished for more.

\* \* \*

It was taking a lot to stay conscious and keep pouring out the heat, but Vince wasn't quite at his breaking point yet. He didn't know if he'd gotten more mentally fortified or if the scalding temperature was somehow weakening the power of her song, but he'd managed to resist the ever-growing pull of sleep so far. It was getting harder; his eyes were beginning to stay closed a little bit longer with each blink. Still, Vince kept his focus aimed at the tan girl's kneeling form.

He could still change up his tactics. One blast of electricity and her medley would grow quiet. Throwing lightning was dangerous; it was so easy



to send too much. Had he been in a more rational frame of mind, he never would have used it at all, even against Michael. Still, he knew it would work, it would definitely give them the win. Didn't that make it worth the risk?

His eyes lingered in the closed position for nearly five seconds this time. Vince shook his head to cast away some of the mental fog. When his eyes settled again, they found themselves looking down at his feet, at a smear of red that stained the concrete beneath him. Camille's blood. They'd cleaned it well, but it would take a professional to coax the red liquid from the porous surface. She'd been hurt so badly trying to win for them. He needed to win this, for her.

Vince looked away from the ground and back at his target. His right hand cupped as he shifted a bit of his focus. The trick to electricity had finally been revealed to him by Professor Fletcher. You didn't aim it like fire; instead you visualized it coming back to you from the target, creating an imaginary circuit that the energy would naturally flow along. He visualized that central point on Selena's shoulder, a safe distance away from her weary, straining face and her delicately slender torso. His stomach churned. She just looked so damn weak already. Maybe the heat would win out over the song. Maybe he didn't have to risk hurting her like this.

Vince took another long blink, but forced himself to reopen his eyes one last time. This time, in the initial blariness that accompanied such an act, he swore that for a moment it was Camille herself he was staring at. His resolution tightened and he knew which attack path he had to take.

\* \* \*

She never heard him slump to the floor. The first indication Selena got that she'd won was when the next sweet gasp of oxygen felt only painful rather than torturous. Greedy gulps of air that were merely uncomfortable followed, and only after she'd pulled in all she could hold did she look across the cell to her opponent. He was sprawled out on the floor; a visible trickle of blood ran from under his temple. He must have fallen so hard that he struck the floor. Selena was impressed. That meant he hadn't gone down gradually; he'd managed to stay standing until her spell overtook him entirely. Not many people had that kind of willpower.

"The winner of this match is Selena Wilkins," Professor Fletcher called through the room. His voice sounded strange, almost alien when contrasted to the beautiful song she'd been weaving around them. She pulled herself slowly to her feet, pausing for a moment to wonder just when she'd

even fallen down, then walked over to check on Vince. His chest was rising and his breathing seemed steady. That was good; anything else could be fixed by the healers.

\* \* \*

“Shit,” Mary swore under her breath. “He almost had her.”

“No kidding. I can’t believe he got so close to winning,” Nick commented. “I underestimated that guy.”

“You... you knew he would lose?”

“Of course. Vince against Selena, anyone could have told you how that would end.”

“Then why send him instead of Roy?”

“Because it’s not that he lost, it’s how he lost. He did it without showing any more of his power than was absolutely necessary.”

“Damn it, Nick, did you really think that was more important than us winning this thing?”

“Don’t be silly, we were never going to win,” Nick chided her. “All I’ve been doing is making sure our losses were manageable.”

“So that’s it? It’s all over?”

“Certainly not. I’ve worked quite hard to manipulate them into giving us this final match-up.”

“Rich versus Roy? He already beat him way back in the first year trials.”

“That was a long time ago,” Roy rumbled from behind them. Both had heard him approach, but neither had felt the need to curb the conversation.

“Quite right. I’m sure after all this time of having a defeat nagging at his ego, Roy has put more thought than any of us at just how to overcome someone like Rich.”

“You’re damn right,” Roy agreed, flashing his teammate a dazzling grin before heading out the door. It wasn’t his usual smarmy smirk, nor was it his debonair cowboy charm smile. No, the smile on Roy’s face was like that of hunting dog that had finally been let off the leash. It spoke of eagerness, of hunger, and above all, of the thrill that was currently coursing through his

excited bones.

“Settle in, folks,” Nick called to the rest of the room. “I promise, this should be one interesting show.”

## 119.

Rich was waiting patiently when Roy entered the cell; a confident smile rested just above his dark goatee. The taller combatant moved across the room slowly, eyes watching his opponent for any signs of aggression as he took his starting position.

“Just like old times, huh?”

Roy nodded curtly. “Looks like it.”

“You folks really did an impressive job. More than any of us expected. I think we have a whole new level of respect for you all.”

“Uh huh. But you still plan on winning.”

“Well, obviously.”

“Obviously.”

“Is everyone ready to begin?” Professor Fletcher asked for the final time that day.

Roy looked over at the small holes where sound entered the room. “I’m ready.”

“I was born ready,” Rich raised.

“Then this match has begun.”

Roy whipped his head back in Rich’s direction and took off at a dead sprint. He reared up his arm in a clothesline that would have taken off Rich’s head, along with a healthy portion of his torso. The aggressive attack took Rich by surprise, leaving him no time to counter. His only bit of fortune was that Roy had telegraphed the charge so blatantly that he was able to throw himself to the side and roll back to his feet in a single motion. Roy’s charge kept right on going; the tall warrior never even stopped until he struck the concrete wall and bounced back. It was only after seeing this collision that Rich grasped exactly what was happening.

“You’re fighting with your eyes closed.”

“Bingo bucko.” Roy wasted not a single moment; he came running at Rich once more. This time Rich was more careful in his motions, moving to

the side as quietly as possible but staying standing the entire time. Roy bounced off another wall and came to a stop. He didn't merely stand in place after the impact; his entire body grew still as he worked to perceive the world around him without the benefit of vision.

"This is idiotic; you can't really expect to win with just running after me blindly," Rich pointed out. Since he was powerful and quick, his own overwhelming ability hadn't provided much practice with thinking in terms of strategy. Or in knowing the importance of silence when an opponent is tracking by sound.

"Actually, I can't lose," Roy disagreed.

"How do you figure?"

"Simple math. No time limit plus my endless endurance minus your very human ability to get tired equal an eventual hit."

"No, it... that's crazy. You're just imitating Nick's antics."

"Important difference: I'm not Nick and you're not Chad. For him it was a way to stay in the game; for me it neutralizes your ability completely. Sooner or later I'll connect, and once is all it takes." With that, Roy rocketed toward Rich once more, powerful legs pounding quickly across the concrete. He missed by a healthy margin, running even faster as he passed Rich's now slightly-panicked form. When he struck the wall he didn't pause, he merely reoriented himself and dashed forward again, bounding forth like a well-muscled ping-pong ball. Rich was able to duck this charge too, but as he moved onto safer ground he found himself taking a deeper breath than normal.

He watched the madman smack into concrete and take off again and a slow realization began to sink through Rich's brain. Roy was right. He didn't get tired, hitting the wall didn't hurt him, and there was no clock running that would end things for them. Eventually he'd get lucky or Rich would get worn out. It was a useless strategy in a real fight, but under only these circumstances it was a bit of insane brilliance.

Rich's respect for his opponent rose right along with his fear of the situation he'd put himself in.

\* \* \*

"Oooh, nearly got him that time," Nick said cheerfully as the group

watched Rich flail out of the way against yet another of Roy's assaults.

"He's getting pretty worn out," Mary said, narrating the battle with the aid of mental eavesdropping. "He's already beginning to wonder how many more dodges he has left in him."

"Doesn't help that Roy seems to be getting more accurate," Alex pointed out.

"It's a vicious cycle that works in our favor," Nick explained. "The more tired Rich gets, the harder he breathes, the harder he breathes, the easier he is to locate by sound, the easier he is to locate by sound, the more accurate Roy gets, which leads to more dodging and more exhaustion."

"I can't believe beating someone like Rich is this simple," Alex said.

"It isn't. There are ridiculously few situations where you can close your eyes and just swing 'til you miss. The cell, the rules, and the pairing all worked together to make this viable. Plus, of us all, Roy is the only one more or less immune to a normal human's capacity for physical damage. That means Rich has no venue for counterattack. If it was anyone else on this team he probably would have come up with and launched some sort of assault. Might not have worked, but he would have had a shot."

"This was your goal all along, wasn't it? Literally, this specific match," Mary asked.

Nick nodded. "Most of the others would shake out more or less the same if we did them a hundred times. This was a bad team for us to fight: they had two people that used techniques we had no immunity to, and one of our best fighters was stuck on the bench due to circumstance."

"Who?"

"Vince. The only person on Team Two with physical abilities is Chad, who would crush Vince. The others are either girls, opponents who lack any enhanced abilities regarding their body, or those who are able to nullify an opponent through sound or sight. That knack of his for taking it to another level when protecting people cuts both ways. He holds back too much when he feels like his opponent is significantly weaker. In trying not to be a bully, he would underestimate them and get caught by surprise. I thought seeing Camille go down might give him an extra push, but I guess putting him against a girl just made him determined not to see a repeat of what happened to her."

“Hey, he almost beat Selena,” Alex countered.

“That he did, in the most non-combative way possible. Haven’t you wondered why he didn’t just blast her with electricity before he fell too deep under her spell?”

“I thought he was focusing on the heat.”

“Which would have been unnecessary with the application of a ranged tasing. No, he didn’t want to hurt her. It would have played like that in pretty much any match. The only variable here was Rich. I knew he could beat any one of us in an open situation; however, in one like this... oh look, I think Roy’s about to prove my point for me.”

\* \* \*

It had been a matter of inches. Rich almost wished it had been more of a margin so that he couldn’t look back and chide himself for not moving just that little bit faster. He could visualize it perfectly. Not that it made any difference in his current situation. He winced as he felt the grip around his forearm tighten.

“Hmm, feels pretty thin. I’ll have to be careful with this,” Roy said, a note of malicious glee almost palpable in his voice.

“This doesn’t mean anything,” Rich replied. “You can’t just crush my head. You can’t use lethal force.”

“True. However, the other option is just to make you forfeit. And last I checked, nobody has ever died from repeated breaks to the arms. At least, not immediately.”

“You’re bluffing. That’s torture.”

Roy tightened his grip several degrees more. “Maybe I am. But I bet I’m willing to go further to win this than you want to find out.”

Rich looked at the calm determination etched on his opponent’s face, and all at once he found himself believing Roy implicitly. “I give up!”

“This match’s winner is Roy Daniels,” Professor Fletcher announced.

“You’re damn right it is,” Roy agreed.

Vince didn't snap back to consciousness as much as he sluggishly drifted into it. Whether the gradual awakening was an effect of the blow to his head or Selena's song would be difficult to determine without trial and error, a method Vince wouldn't be terribly eager to engage in. He blinked a few times as the smooth white tiles of the infirmary ceiling slowly came into focus. It took a moment, but eventually he figured out that he'd been laid down on one of the cushy cots for healing treatment. With great care he began to pull himself up to a sitting position. He might not remember smacking his face to the concrete, but the dull ache at the apex of his temple and forehead told the story quite well. Vince had taken enough knocks on the noggin to know that sometimes reorienting yourself came with dizziness and motion sickness.

This time, thankfully, he didn't encounter any serious trouble. Now that his torso was upright, he could look around the room. The first thing he saw was also the last, because it so utterly ensnared his focus that all thoughts of observing his surroundings were abandoned. It was, of course, Camille, positioned a few feet away from him and still sleeping soundly. She'd been cleaned up and bandaged, but from the looks of the unattended scratches on her face, she hadn't been healed yet. Her rest seemed peaceful, so Vince assumed she'd at least been given something for the pain. It still didn't quite explain why she was still untreated.

"Oh, you're up already," said a male voice from behind him.

Vince turned to see a fellow student who looked familiar but whose name either escaped or had never been known to Vince in the first place. "Who are you?"

"I'm Ed, one of the healers on staff today. And you should take it easy, that was a pretty nasty hit you got."

"I'm fine," Vince assured him. "Why hasn't Camille been healed yet?"

"Her injuries weren't life threatening, so I treated her, gave her some pain meds, and made sure she was comfortable until she woke up."

"That doesn't explain why you didn't heal her," Vince said, swinging his feet to the ground and pulling himself to a standing position. He realized he might have looked more intimidating than intended when Ed took a few rapid steps backward.



“Look, I wasn’t trying to neglect her or anything. It’s just that with those injuries to her face I thought it would be better to let her heal herself. My power only accelerates the body’s own processes, so it can leave scars. From what I’ve seen, hers negates every injury entirely. I just thought she would prefer it that way.”

“I can understand that.” Although Vince wasn’t especially vain, he did get the concept as a whole. “I must say, it’s a little surprising that they’d have a match day with only one healer, especially one with your limitations.”

“There’s an actual healer on staff who oversees us,” Ed corrected. “She likes to let us do most of the work, since we’re the ones getting trained. Unfortunately, there was a bit of an incident with the other group, so she was pulled away to the cells.”

“I see.” Vince turned his attention back to his Camille, who stirred softly as she readjusted.

“We’ve got two other students as well, but one had her own project to work on today, and obviously Camille was in the matches.”

“Camille works down here?”

“Sure, all the healer students do. It’s part of our training,” Ed explained. “Plus, it saves the staff from having to hire more than one dedicated person with healing abilities. Those can be pretty expensive.”

“Where does she find the time?” Vince wondered aloud. His head throbbed once more, and unconsciously he reached up to touch the tender area. He was a bit surprised to find his fingers brushing gauze rather than skin. “You didn’t heal me either?”

“Just a bit of a patching up.”

“I’d like to be healed now, please.”

“Are you sure? That gash you got along with the impact was pretty deep. If I use my power you’ll end up with a scar by the hairline on your temple. Camille will probably be up soon.”

“I don’t care about the scar. Just heal me, please.” Vince could deal with scars; he’d had an abundance of them before the incident when he was sixteen. What he couldn’t deal with was the knowledge that something could be affecting his head. He’d come a long way in getting comfortable with his powers; however, anything that might inadvertently make him lose control

was far too dangerous to tolerate. Especially with innocent people so close by.

“I guess it’s your choice,” Ed agreed reluctantly. He walked over and carefully pressed his fingers onto Vince’s forehead. There was a moment of nothing, and then Vince felt as though the wound was being swarmed by mosquito bites. It itched beyond description, beyond even understanding. Before he could cry out, let alone try to scratch it, the sensation was gone.

“Sorry about that. I know it’s pretty unpleasant, but it works.”

Vince tenderly pulled off the bandage and felt around. Sure enough, there was no tenderness or pain anywhere on his noggin. Ed’s method might not be as painless as Camille’s, but it did still produce results.

“Thank you.”

“It’s what I’m here for. You’re free to go now; we were only holding you until the wound was treated.”

“I’ll stay here until Camille wakes up, if that’s all right.” Vince’s tone and expression were both the peak of politeness; however, there was a buried edge in his voice that told Ed one way or another he was staying, so it had damned well better be all right.

“Sure, no rules against it, but don’t you want to know how your team did?”

“I’m certain they’ll come straight here as soon the match is concluded,” Vince said. “Besides, I already know how it ended. We tied.”

Ed cocked an eyebrow of curiosity. “You a telepath?”

Vince smiled at him in reply. “No. I just know my friends.” He pulled a hard plastic chair over from the wall and set it next to Camille’s bed. It became evident within seconds that it would be an intensely uncomfortable place to sit while he waited. That was okay; Vince was well acquainted with discomfort. He settled in and trained his eyes on his wounded teammate. He would be here when she woke up.

He owed her that much at least.

## 121.

Nick had just finished putting on his regular shoes when Professor Pendleton entered the locker room. The uniform boots, much like the rest of the Lander mandatory outfits, were comfortable and functional, but whoever designed them didn't have much regard for fashion. Not that Nick could throw stones: his above-ground garb was a t-shirt, jeans, and bright green sneakers. He'd have been turned away from his own casino in this outfit, but it was a necessary camouflage to blend in.

"You didn't want to go to the infirmary with your friends?" Professor Pendleton asked.

"Nah. I know Vince and Camille are fine, we've got good people on staff here. Besides, standing around awkwardly, trying to acknowledge someone got hurt without talking about it, that's not my idea of a good time. I'll swoop by after things have settled down a bit."

"I can appreciate the validity of that strategy. Speaking of, how do you think things went today?"

"Are you fucking kidding? We pulled out a tie against Chad's team and I didn't have to sacrifice a single team secret to do it. I'm not even religious and I feel like I should be lighting a saint candle in thanks."

"It was a pretty surprising outcome. I got a briefing from Professor Fletcher. One thing struck me, however; it seemed like if you'd let Camille use her full power you would have won." Professor Pendleton settled down on a nearby bench as they talked. Given his tall, lanky frame, he looked more like a squatting bird as he hunkered down on the low-seated wooden plank.

"First off, getting Camille to use her ability would have been a fight in itself. Even if she'd agreed, it would have been halfhearted and hesitant because Vince was watching. But if, and that's a big if, she'd managed to win, it would have just put Chad into defensive mode. He would have played it safer, used Will or Rich in the two-person team as support instead of letting them run their own matches. If she'd done it and lost then we'd have gotten the same outcome, plus we'd be down a match."

"Well-reasoned," Professor Pendleton agreed. "I take it Camille's match was also a play to get Will sent out?"

Nick nodded. "That kind of shit leaves a foul taste in anyone's mouth. Will doesn't have bad blood with any of us. Hell, all of us consider him a friend. He was the logical choice to make sure there wasn't a repeat of what happened with Camille and Sasha."

"I think we can all be glad that was an isolated incident. The Mary and Alice pairing was quite a cunning move, I must say. You hid her new ability and utilized it at the same time."

"Yeah, I owe Alex some thanks for that one. Until he pulled his trick I had no idea how I was going to convince those girls to pair up for the match."

"You intended to put them together before you thought of hiding Alice's power?"

"Sure. My biggest fear was that Chad would play Rich in response to someone we sent out. Camille neutralized the first opportunity for that by forcing Sasha out and Alice neutralized the second."

"Why would Alice stop him from using Rich?"

"Because of what happened at Halloween. Assuming Chad believes Rich didn't induce a dead-mother-based fantasy on purpose, which given Rich's lack of constant bruises seems like a fair assumption, he would never willfully put Alice under Rich's spell again. If he didn't mean to do it, then there's no guarantee it won't happen again. Chad has a parent he never knew, too. He won't risk putting Alice through that pain again, not unless he has to," Nick explained.

"I see; so Alice ensures he won't be sent out in round two, and by then it doesn't matter because if Chad nominates Rich you play Roy, and if he uses Selena you play Vince," Professor Pendleton said, continuing the path of logic.

"Bingo. Selena's match was lost to us anyway, as was anyone Vince tangled with, so I just had to make sure and condense the losses as much as possible. Little bastard surprised me, for a minute I thought he was going to pull off a win." Nick finished tying his shoes and stood up from the smooth bench. His back made a dull crackling sound as he rose, reminding him that he'd neglected his stretching exercises as of late.

"Yes. That loss was... unfortunate."

Nick felt something in his mind bristle. There had been a pause, a hint

of a tone almost imperceptible in the way Professor Pendleton said 'unfortunate.'

"What do you mean?"

"Nothing, nothing. Just saying it was too bad he couldn't have pulled that off. It would have given your team an actual win rather than a draw. And, of course, winning against someone like Selena would have reflected well on Vince's record." Professor Pendleton's smile was casual and his words were light, but his eyes were locked steadily on Nick's face. It was the body language of someone trying to say something without actually saying it. Fortunately, Nick was well-versed in the art of subtle communication.

"True, Selena has placed quite well on most challenges. Of course, Vince is no slouch himself."

"Well, he tries his best," Professor Pendleton said. "His only wins during his time at Lander have been against Michael Clark earlier this year and when he and Alex teamed up against Thomas Castillo in the freshman midterm. You can see why it would have been quite a coup if he'd gotten the better of a high performer like Selena."

"Only two wins? I feel like it's been more than that."

"You're no doubt including last year's kidnapping as well as some extracurricular events which I can neither encourage nor officially know about, but unfortunately only official matches can be used for student evaluation." Professor Pendleton's eyes were practically bursting out of his sockets by now. Nick had to assume the professor's fear centered on being overheard more than being watched.

"I'm sure he'll get to strut his stuff in our last team event," Nick assured him.

"Let's hope so. I know nepotism and networking are considered the great forces that get one ahead in the outside world, but here in the HCP the only factor that will get you to the next year is dedication. That goes for you, too, you know." Professor Pendleton rose from his strange perch and headed toward the door. "Don't forget, you have an assignment due Wednesday on code breaking."

Once the professor was gone, Nick sat back down. Whatever he was trying to say had to have been in his parting words. This week's assignment was in tonal recognition, so the code breaking thing had been a heavy-handed

hint. That was the direction, which meant the clue was in the first part. He'd said that nepotism and networking were the great forces for advancement. That didn't seem to pertain too much to Vince. He got along with everyone, but he wasn't the type to use friendship to get ahead. Besides, the only teacher he'd spent truly extensive time with was Coach George, so that wouldn't be helping him anytime soon. As for nepotism, that was even less likely. Alice might have a dad in high places, but Vince didn't have anyone. After all, he was an orphan with no parents. Well, unless you counted-

"FUCK!" Nick yelled, driving his fist into the nearest locker. There was an impressive dent that would take a workman three hours to fix on Monday. Nick didn't even notice; his marvelous brain was whirring with such intensity it was nearly audible. He'd missed it. It was obvious, it was right fucking there, and he'd missed it. Nick took a deep breath and tried to get calm. It didn't work.

He'd missed it. And now there was a good chance that Vince was completely fucked.

## 122.

"I still can't believe you guys pulled that off," Hershel said in awe. Mary nuzzled closer to him; the two were lounging on his bed, looking at the television without watching it.

"Sure, all it took to get a tie was two injuries and what I'm pretty sure was divine intervention in the form of Nick's lineup working," Mary sighed.

"Admittedly, it wasn't perfect, but it was still impressive," Hershel countered. "And to be honest, it was just what Roy needed. He's hidden it well, but he's been really down about this whole issue with hitting his limit. Finding a way to beat Rich was a pretty good morale boost."

"I know, and I'm actually happy with the outcome, I just don't want to get too overconfident," Mary replied. "We had a whole lot of things break our way. Nine times out of ten, that team would beat us definitively."

"Good thing we got the one out of ten then," Hershel said, giving his girlfriend a loving squeeze.

"Very good thing. I'm happy Roy is feeling better, too. I've heard his thoughts and I know the inability to break through that wall has been eating at him."

"It's getting pretty bad," Hershel agreed. "Professor Fletcher has run through every method he knows of, and Roy's read up on gobs of people with his power, yet so far we've seen zero progress."

"It's not something people like to talk about, but every one of us does have limits. Eventually we all hit a threshold we can't cross, no matter hard we train. We're not gods, after all; just people with special abilities," Mary said.

"I know, and that's the scariest part of it. If this is it, if this is as far as Roy can go, then I'm not sure we'll ever make it to Hero. There's just too much of a gap between what we can do and what strongmen at that level are capable of."

"Wasn't your dad a Hero? I thought Roy had his ability, and usually the second generation is equal to or stronger than the first," Mary pointed out.

"Usually is a pretty key word there," Hershel said. "But Roy doesn't

have my dad's power. Not exactly. His power was adaption. If he got injured, his body would toughen itself so the same thing wouldn't hurt him anymore. For example, when he was a kid, he took a nasty tumble off his bike and scratched up his knees and elbows. A week later he fell off again, and this time his skin wasn't even raw."

"Didn't he have super strength too?"

"Same principle. He'd fail to lift something, and within a day he'd be strong enough to do it. By the time he was an adult, his defensive and offensive capabilities were already on par with famous Heroes."

"Strange that the son of a man whose very ability was breaking through limits would hit his own so early on," Mary said offhandedly. "Chalk another one up to the mystery of how these powers work."

"Yeah, it is pretty weird." Hershel's voice had grown a bit distant, and Mary had to actively quell the desire to listen on where his mind had wandered. She managed to resist, but if she'd tuned in, all she would have heard was him reminiscing over a memory from childhood. It was one that Roy blocked out, but still haunted Hershel in moments like these.

It was about a month after Roy had come into the picture. He and his father had been sitting in a park, eating ice cream on a warm afternoon. The details had grown blurry, but the one piece that was still sharp was his father's hand patting Hershel's head and his voice telling Hershel that one day the two of them would surpass him by leap and bounds. Even now, looking back, it didn't feel like speculation. It seemed like his father knew something, something that was becoming increasingly more important as Roy stayed still while the rest of the class moved forward.

Mary poked him in the ribs. "Hey, you in there?"

"Sorry, I was just thinking about something," Hershel said. Gazing at Mary, it sunk in that if Roy couldn't make the cut, they would fall on a very different path than Mary and the others. Hershel didn't want to lose future memories of the HCP, even if they were secondhand. He didn't want to live in a different world than all of his friends. Most of all, he didn't want to feel his brother's frustration and fear anymore. Roy had been an ass to him for a lot of their life, but when push came to shove, he'd always looked out for his weaker brother. It was Hershel's turn to do something Roy couldn't do.

"When is spring break?" Hershel asked.



“Like, two weeks away. Didn’t you see the posters for the freshman river trip?”

“Must have missed those.”

“Why do you ask?”

“Just figuring out how I’m going to spend my time off. Wanted to know how much prep time there was.”

“I hope you come up with something fun. We could all use some stress relief after our semester so far.”

“That we could,” Hershel agreed. It was the only phrase he could come up with that sounded on the same page but wouldn’t count as a lie. His spring break would be anything but fun. It would be hard to keep from Roy, too. Fortunately, Roy didn’t often reminisce on Hershel’s memories of Mary, so if he was lucky, the other brother wouldn’t notice this harebrained idea lurking in their shared mind. It would take damn near a miracle, but after today’s spectacle, Hershel found himself a bit more inclined to hope for one.

## 123.

"I can't believe you lost to a song," Camille chuckled lightly. "Didn't you think to just stick your fingers in your ears?" She and Vince were in the dining hall eating a late dinner, almost alone in the spacious enclosure. Everyone from both teams, with the exception of Sasha, had come to check on her in the infirmary; however, it was past afternoon by the time she finally woke up, so all but Vince had eventually needed to leave for other classes. The pain drugs they'd given her had evidently worked better than expected, as Camille usually classified herself as a light sleeper. Once she finally came around, it was a quick matter to heal herself, and once Vince had caught her up on the match outcomes, they'd both realized they were ravenous.

"Generally it's a bad idea to stick things in your ears that are putting out heat in the hundreds of degrees," Vince pointed out. He took a bite of low-quality hamburger and swallowed it with some effort. "Besides, it wouldn't have worked."

"Why not?"

"I don't totally understand it, but Alex explained to me and Nick once why you don't have to hear Selena's music to be entranced by it. He said it was like how someone can turn their bass so high that you feel in rippling through your body."

"My cousin has a car set up like that. He gave me a ride home from swim practice once and I nearly threw up," Camille recalled. It normally would have weakened her appetite, but if the lukewarm chicken tenders on her plate couldn't turn her stomach then some childhood memory of discomfort didn't stand a chance.

"Right. So, basically the same thing. Even though you might not register it, your body still absorbs her song. Evidently that's all it takes. It's why Alex created a technique that pushed back all sound, not only whatever was around his ears."

"Good luck for him that he did," Camille said. She dragged a limp, soggy fry through ketchup in hopes that it would improve the taste. It didn't. "It sounds like Will would have had that match sewn up if he hadn't pulled that trick out of his hat."

"Yeah, everyone did a really amazing job today." Vince didn't say

‘except me’ because he didn’t have too. He felt like everyone was already thinking it. So instead he cut his sentence short and gulped down some flat soda that had come with his meal. Camille heard the unspoken words in his voice anyway.

“I’m sorry, Vince. I didn’t mean to laugh. It just seemed funny because of how strong I know you are. After I saw you fight Michael, it was hard to imagine anyone beating you. Selena is powerful in her own right, and there’s no shame in losing to her.”

“She is, she’s incredible,” Vince agreed. “But I think I could have beaten her if I’d used electricity.”

“Let me guess, you held back because you were scared of hurting her?”

Vince looked up from his food into the compassionate stare of his dinner-mate. “How did you know?”

“It’s who you are. All this strength is still relatively new to you, so you err on the side of caution rather than risk seriously injuring someone.”

“In this case that weakness of mine cost us an upset win. That’s what’s eating at me; I had the chance to really make a difference and I couldn’t pull the trigger on it.” Vince noticed his hand had involuntarily clenched into fist as it rested on the table. A smaller hand, one far more delicate than his own, settled on top of it and squeezed.

“Kindness is not a weakness,” Camille said firmly. “The fact that you care so much about other people is part of why you do make a difference. Maybe not in some stupid match, but in the world as a whole.”

“You think too much of me,” Vince replied. His hand relaxed, and it could have been his imagination but he would have sworn Camille’s lingered on top of his for a few moments after. Then it was gone, and they were back to working their way through the culinary catastrophe set before them.

“So what is Nick planning for celebration, anyway? Monster movie marathon or maybe a night at some sketchy dive bar?”

“Actually, he said he wanted to take the night to reflect on the day’s events,” Vince informed her. “I guess it is tactician stuff.”

\* \* \*

Nick was well through his sixth glass of gin at the moment in question. He was at a bar far from campus; the cab ride here had been nearly forty dollars and now he'd have to spend the same to get back. It was worth the cash to be here. This was a dark lounge with thick smoke in the air, a place where no one asked for an ID because if you had the clout to know about it, your business was welcome. There were places like it all over America, and Nick made it a point to know the nearest one whenever he was stuck in a new city.

He sat alone in a high-backed leather chair, vision trained on a fake fireplace with a projection of flames dancing across it. There were people to talk to and things to do of which he could avail himself, but that wasn't why he'd come here. Nick needed to be alone. He needed to drink in misery and have a night to chastise himself for such an unforgivable failure. He needed penance, and more importantly he needed focus.

Vince was in danger of being kicked out. It made sense; all policies aside, the son of Globe would be no more welcome in the HCP than the son of Hitler at a bar mitzvah. That it wasn't a blood relation or an official adoption was even worse; it meant the little protection that applied to children of criminal Supers could be sidestepped. It couldn't be an easy process, at least, otherwise they would have drummed him out already.

Another hearty gulp of gin smoothed his nerves as Nick continued to work through the problem. So, someone wanted Vince out based on Chad's accusations. They probably couldn't eliminate him based solely on something so flimsy, however. Professor Pendleton had specifically mentioned Vince's sub-par record in official matches, so there was a good chance that was the avenue being pursued. Nick took another long drink as the false flames flickered. Vince was middle of the pack. He'd improved, but his tendency toward caution meant he never truly showcased his skills. If things kept up at this pace, he could fail to advance to third year without raising too much suspicion. Friends would be sad, but no one would be able to prove it was intentional discrimination. Not with an official record like his.

Nick cleaned out the glass and motioned for another. So, the solution was to make sure that Vince put on such a display of power in the final match that failing to advance him would raise all manner of hell. It had taken Nick six drinks to figure out the What, now all that remained was coming up with the How. He suspected it would require more gin than this bar stocked, but he was willing to find out.

## 124.

Wednesday morning, Mary found a note inside her gym locker, resting delicately on top of her uniform. It politely informed her to get dressed and report to Dean Blaine's office rather than the gym. She mentally flipped through recent events to see if anyone had committed any transgression a captain might be held accountable for. Nothing really stuck out to her, and she usually kept close tabs on Nick's thoughts in case he was planning something she wanted advanced warning about. Unfortunately, he was good at controlling the direction of his mind's wandering when around her, so it was possible she'd missed something. She arrived at the dean's office to find the door open and two men waiting inside.

One was the dean, seated behind his expansive desk, and the other was Chad, looking as uncertain about his presence here as she felt. She wondered if it had something to do with last week's match, though she couldn't imagine why. Everyone had recovered and moved on. Sasha still seemed to stay as far away from their team as possible during gym, but that hardly seemed like anything the dean would involve himself with.

"Good morning, Mary," Dean Blaine greeted her. "Please shut the door behind you and take a seat."

"Yes, sir." She closed it gently then settled into one of the open chairs set before the dean's desk.

"I'm sure you're both wondering why I've called you here, and I see no reason to keep you in suspense. As you both are probably aware, in your class you represent the strongest combatants of each sex. This is no small feat, especially given the impressive talents of those you are in competition with," Dean Blaine said. Mary had a sneaking suspicion he'd given this speech before. There was something polished about it, like he'd had time to overthink the delivery.

"With such high office comes a great deal of respect," Dean Blaine continued. "However, it also comes with certain responsibilities and obligations. As others were tasked to shepherd you, you will be watching over the next generation."

"Excuse me, but I'm not sure what you're talking about," Mary admitted.

“Isn’t it obvious? I would have thought you two noticed the posters outside the gym by now.”

“Posters? The only posters I’ve seen are for the river trip,” Chad said.

“Precisely,” Dean Blaine affirmed.

“I’m confused,” Mary said.

“Ah yes, I forgot you didn’t attend last year’s outing. The river trip is largely funded by the school; however, we do not send teachers as supervision. We instead send our top sophomore students from each sex to handle any issues that might arise.”

Mary raised a very suspicious eyebrow. “What kind of issues?”

“Last year there were some fights, one person got lost, and Allen set the forest on fire,” Chad supplied in what he thought was a helpful manner.

“That doesn’t really sound like my cup of tea,” Mary said.

“I, too, would like to decline the honor,” Chad seconded. “I only went last year as part of a bargain with Angela DeSoto.”

“I can certainly understand the sentiment,” Dean Blaine said graciously. “Unfortunately, this isn’t something you’re allowed to decline. It is an assignment just like any other you receive in the HCP.”

“That doesn’t seem fair,” Mary shot back. “Why do we have to spend our time off doing work when everyone else gets to go have fun?”

“For one thing, HCP is not bound by traditional school schedules. For another, most of our chaperones will tell you that even with the weight of their responsibility, they still had fun. As to fairness, it is actually very fair. Someone had to do it for your class, and two of the current freshmen will be doing it next year. And more than any other reason, because this provides a training opportunity unlike any other you’re likely to receive.”

“Training?” Chad perked up visibly at this word.

“Indeed. You’re both captains of your teams, and presuming you become full-fledged Heroes, you’ll likely continue to find yourselves in such a capacity. You both are powerful, resourceful, and trustworthy. People turn to you; that’s why you were chosen for those leadership roles. Not all teams in your life will be made up of friends, however. The Hero world is chaotic. Sometimes you’ll have to work with people you don’t know, or even ones you

dislike.”

“How does that factor into us watching Supers get drunk on a river?” Mary asked.

Dean Blaine gave her a smile that said she’d stepped exactly where he wanted her to. “My dear girl, if you can corral drunk Supers in their late teens then there is no combination of people on this planet you won’t be able to coordinate. It teaches patience, flexibility, and working outside your comfort zones.”

Both students stayed quiet for a moment and digested his words. It was Mary who eventually reached a conclusion and spoke. “I suppose you do make a compelling case.”

“While it is not optional, I do want you both to get something out of it.”

“Right. When you put it that way, I guess my answer is yes,” Mary said. She’d played enough chess with Mr. Numbers to know when she was beaten.

“If it is official training I will gladly participate,” Chad added.

“Glad you’re both on board. You can go ahead and walk over to gym now. I’ll get you the details of what’s expected and where to be once the date is a bit closer,” Dean Blaine said. He gestured for them to stand and Mary complied. Chad, however, stayed where he was.

“I actually have another matter I’d like to discuss with the dean in private,” Chad said as both people stared at him curiously.

“Very well,” Dean Blaine accepted.

Mary took the cue and departed. Part of her wanted to linger around the area, but she knew it wouldn’t have done any good. She couldn’t read the mind of either man in the room, and she had a sneaking suspicion that Dean Blaine’s office was completely soundproof when the door was shut.

Back in the office, Dean Blaine looked at Chad curiously. “What else did you want to talk about?”

“Actually it’s still about the river trip,” Chad explained. “It really is mandatory, right? That’s not just something you said to get her to go along with it?”

“It really is mandatory. You aren’t the first reluctant chaperones we’ve had. Actually, it is more the rule than the exception since we tend to pick responsible students for the role. Ms. DeSoto was easily the most enthusiastic person to get the job I’ve ever had,” Dean Blaine clarified.

“All right then. If it’s an official HCP activity then an HCP official can explain to my mother why I won’t be coming home as expected over spring break,” Chad replied. “I took enough guilt for it last year.”

Dean Blaine’s face grew a few shades paler. “Miriam is expecting you? I assumed you would be staying here to train.”

“Nope. I told her I’d be home the whole week. I hope you’ve got a good way to make it up to her.”

“I suppose I’ll have to think of one,” Dean Blaine replied. Miriam was not a woman he enjoyed being on the bad side of, especially when it came to her son. He’d miscalculated on this one, and if he didn’t come up with something pretty damn good, he’d be regretting it.

“Good luck with that,” Chad said with a wicked smile. It was a dash of humor at Dean Blaine’s expense that would have been commonplace in anyone his age, yet it left Dean Blaine with a smile of his own once the young man was gone from the office. Before coming to Lander, Chad wouldn’t have even summoned up that small spark of laughter. Either the HCP or the people in it were having a positive effect on him, and that made even Miriam’s substantial wrath worth bearing.

Dean Blaine’s eyes darted to the phone then looked away. It might be worth bearing, but that was no reason to face it without some sort of a game plan.



## 125.

“That totally sucks,” Alice said, not quite whining but not keeping too far from it either. “I was looking forward to actually hanging out with you over break.”

“Especially since you couldn’t be with us last year,” Vince added.

The Melbrook group was in the common area, clustered about in various reclining positions. Mary had waited until everyone was together to break the news of her hijacked spring break plans, unleashing a small current of surprise and disappointment through their thoughts. One mind exuded phrases of relief, and it was all Mary could do to keep from looking shocked when she realized who it was.

“It seems unfair that they’d make you do that even though you didn’t go on the trip last year,” Hershel pointed out.

“I could have gone. Me not taking the opportunity doesn’t excuse me from the responsibility tied to getting it in the first place,” Mary replied.

“This is an unfortunate turn of events,” Nick said. “However, it shines a bright light on an issue none of us has previously addressed.” Every one stared at him blankly. Nick let out an exasperated sigh that was only half acting. “What are the rest of us going to do for spring break? We’ve got, like, a week and a few days before it starts and no one has put together any plans.”

“We could stay here and train,” Vince suggested immediately. He glanced at Hershel, expecting him to agree on behalf of Roy, but found the portly young man pointedly avoiding his gaze.

“Let’s just veto that crap off the bat,” Nick replied. “Spring break is a break, not a time for more training. We’ve gone over the resting a muscle analogy before, don’t make me repeat myself.”

“I guess you’re right,” Vince agreed reluctantly. “How about camping?”

“I suppose that’s one to consider,” Nick said. “My own proposal is that we all pitch in and go rent a beach house for the week. They jack the prices up, but we should be able to afford a crappy one.”

“I hate to point this out, but those are usually all booked before

February,” Hershel said. “Roy used to hang out with some kids from a local college back home, and they had to book in November to get anything decent.”

“Huh, well, I guess camping is the frontrunner then,” Nick surmised. He was actually a little surprised that beach trips required so much preparation. All the culture of Vegas was built around the idea of last minute decisions and impromptu trips. Vacations were one of the few areas his extensive training hadn’t prepared him for.

“Not necessarily,” Alice interrupted. “Between the two I’d prefer sun and sand over bugs and dirt. So I vote for beach.”

“I wouldn’t mind the beach,” Vince said. “It just doesn’t seem likely we can get a house to rent.”

“Yeah. So let’s just stay at mine,” Alice offered.

“Waaaaait a minute. You have a beach house?” Nick asked.

“Not ‘a’ beach house, no. We’ve got, like, seven throughout the world. One is in California, only a few hours’ drive away. They mostly go unused; my dad likes to lend them to people he’s in business with to keep relations good.” She stopped talking as she became aware of the surprise and occasional confusion peppering the faces of her friends. “What? You all know I’m rich.”

“I guess we kind of forgot,” Vince admitted. “You don’t bring it up very often.”

Alice shrugged. “It doesn’t really matter that often. This time it did.”

“The girl isn’t wrong about that one,” Nick agreed. “I assume it’s big enough for all of us?”

“It’s got ten bedrooms and two kitchens. We’ll be fine. In fact, we should probably see if any our friends have plans yet. No offense, but with Mary gone, I wouldn’t mind the company of a few more females.”

“We can spread the word and get a headcount through the rest of the week. For now, at least we four have something of a plan,” Nick said.

“Three,” Hershel corrected.

“Pardon me?”

“Three of you. I’ve already got something planned for over break.”

Mary was gripped by the desire to peek inside her boyfriend’s mind and see what secret was motivating him to pass on such fun. Somehow she resisted. Before had been an accident: she’d merely opened herself to the room. This would be intentional prying, and going down that path was the fastest way toward an awkward breakup. At least now she knew why he’d been relieved. He wasn’t going to have to miss time with her since she’d be on the river trip anyway.

“Care to share, or is this some secret training thing?” Nick asked.

“Something like the second. Sorry, guys.”

“It’s okay,” Vince said. “We’d love to have you over break, but if you have something you need to do then we understand.”

“Thanks.” Hershel meant the gratitude, but internally his focus had shifted away from the room’s conversation. Roy was going to notice this memory; it centered around the beach and partying, two of his favorite things. He’d want to know why Hershel turned down the opportunity, which meant the jig was up as far as keeping Roy in the dark on what they were really doing. It had been a tenuous proposition in the first place, but he’d hoped to get at least a few more days along before this happened. At least it was in the afternoon. He could talk to the HCP staff tomorrow before class started. Hopefully they would see where Hershel was coming from. Hopefully.

“So, we three will hit up Alice’s house, along with whichever of our friends want to join. Unless you need to ask permission before we roll out invites?” Nick asked.

“No, I’ll just call the staff and tell them to prep and stock the place,” Alice replied. “My dad is in Indonesia on some trip right now, and even if he were here I doubt he’d care.” If anyone heard the slight touch of bitterness in her voice that came with the statement, they chose to keep it themselves.

“Okay then,” Nick said, quickly paving over Alice’s temporary vulnerability. “I think we’ve got ourselves the making of one hell of a party week.”

## 126.

Professor Fletcher heard the knock at his open door and glanced up from the reports he'd been pretending to read. An unfamiliar husky boy stood a step outside, looking at the professor with a healthy dollop of fear. Professor Fletcher's brain swept through the situation to puzzle out exactly who this kid was. It was too late in the year for any of the freshman to still be portly: three hours of gym a day had shrunk even the heaviest of them. The older students would all still be in tip-top shape as well, so this kid wasn't a participant in the program. Add to that he wasn't wearing a uniform, but he'd still managed to get down here and knew where the offices were. Someone who would have comprehensive knowledge of and access to the HCP, yet clearly wasn't participating in it himself. That narrowed down the subject pool considerably.

"You're the other Daniels boy. Hershel, right?"

"Yes, sir."

"Come on in, then. What can I do for you?"

Hershel moved through the room like a hemophiliac navigating a razor maze, eventually sitting in a chair by the professor's desk with his back straight and his body signaling it was ready to run. "I, um, I came to talk to you about the rest of the classes before spring break."

"What about them?"

"If it's... if it's okay with you, I'd like permission for Roy to miss them."

Normally Professor Fletcher would have suspected a ploy for an extra week of vacation; however, the terror tremors rippling out the kid in front of him said clearly that asking for this was one of the last things he wanted to do. Whatever the reason was, it must have been a pretty damn good one.

"Obviously that isn't going to fly well with all of Roy's teachers, so I'm guessing you've got an explanation for that kind of request?"

Hershel nodded. "I can't let him out until after spring break. I've decided to do something that will really piss- er, I mean, anger him. I don't know how he'll try to sabotage or stop me, so I can't risk it."

"Wild guess: this has something to do with the limit wall he's been

unable to break through,” Professor Fletcher ventured.

“How did you know?”

“Usually someone goes to their favorite professor with this kind of thing, or at least the one they think likes them the best. I’ve spent the most time with him, which means putting up with his ego and his badly-articulated attempt at a Southern drawl, not to mention his tendency to call me a cocksucker when things I suggest don’t work, so I think you’re smart enough to go elsewhere for favors. Unless it concerned the very reason I have put in all that time with him, which would be working past his wall.”

“I suppose that’s fair. Roy’s grown a lot, but he still doesn’t handle frustration particularly well. And yes, I have an idea for how to break through his limit.”

“I’m all ears,” Professor Fletcher said.

“Oh. I have to tell you? I thought if you knew the reason...” Hershel trailed off as he realized he didn’t have much logic to the end of his argument.

“Look, I agree that what you’re proposing is important. More than a week of HCP training, and that’s saying a lot. From the way you’re fidgeting, I think you’re hoping I’ll be the one to explain this to the rest of the professors. Which I will - if, and only if, I believe you’re doing something that could really work and not just waste more time.”

Hershel swallowed and took a deep breath. Once he said it aloud, there was no going back. Roy would be mad, beyond mad, really. This could undo all the progress they’d made in their relationship since coming to Lander. His brother might never forgive him. But... it was all he could do. Roy was always the one who had to face the danger, always the one who had to brave the pain of battle. Hershel would never be able to protect his brother the way Roy watched over him. He could do this, at the very least. He could undertake a mission even Roy couldn’t handle.

“I’m going to see my father.”

Professor Fletcher raised an eyebrow. “I’d gotten the impression from Roy that option was off the table.”

“For him. Not for me. I’ll go and talk to him.”

“And you think he holds the secret to making Roy stronger? Because I’m not exactly new to this and I haven’t found a single thing that works.”

“I think he does. He’s the first trainer Roy ever had. No one knows Roy’s power better than my father. If there is a way for Roy to improve, he would be the one to know it.”

“I can believe that,” Professor Fletcher acknowledged. “But what if he doesn’t? What if he’s just as clueless as the rest of us?”

“Then... then I don’t think Roy and I will be advancing to junior year, will we?”

Professor Fletcher weighed his reaction carefully. The wrong phrasing could dash what tattered hope these two were still holding on to. “At his current level, Roy performs in the upper ranks of the class as far as combat. However, limitations are an issue that is considered here. If he truly can’t get any more powerful, then he wouldn’t be able to hack it at higher levels. It would be irresponsible of us to give an advancement spot to someone we know is going to fail out.”

“I understand,” Hershel said. He really did, too. Hershel got that strong as Roy was, if this was all he could do then it wasn’t enough. The fight with Coach George had illustrated the problem perfectly. Strongmen had to be able to deal damage, and against the upper echelon of Supers, Roy simply couldn’t. “That’s why I have to try to do this. I have to go see my father. If he can’t help then at least we did everything we could. If he can, well, then maybe one day Roy will forgive me.”

“For your sake, I hope so,” Professor Fletcher said. “Fine. You can miss all the classes until spring break. I’ll settle things with the dean and the other professors. I expect a full report on what you learned as soon as you get back, obviously.”

“Of course. Yes, sir.”

“Good. Now, you should probably head back to the surface. I’ve got a class coming up and you have a trip to plan.”

Hershel didn’t need to be told twice; he exited the room so fast that Professor Fletcher was left momentarily wondering if the husky kid had been concealing a super-speed ability.

“Let me ask, do you have any swimsuits that don’t look like they were purchased from a nunnery?” Violet held up a truly awful one-piece that had body-masking ruffles perfectly illustrating her point.

“I like to be comfortable when I swim,” Camille defended weakly.

“And I’d like for the gentleman you’ve got your eye on to not be capable of taking his own peepers off you,” Violet shot back. “Come on, they invited us to a giant beach house for a week of surf, sand, and severe intoxication. The least you can do is offer up a little eye candy.”

Camille shuffled her feet and kept her eyes trained on the floor. “There will be plenty of girls for him to stare at. Half of our class is coming.”

“Oh, don’t be like that,” Violet sighed, setting down her friend’s suit. It had taken her days of wheedling to convince Camille to do a wardrobe evaluation in her dorm before setting off on the trip. “You and I both know he’s not the type to go stupid over some barely-covered breasts. Honestly, he’s so non-aggressive that if not for his history with Sasha I’d be wondering if he played for the other team.”

Camille snorted a laugh. “He can be a little a shy.”

“You can be shy. He’s just... I’m actually not sure what the word is.”

“He’s different,” Camille answered for her, an unexpected smile dancing across her face.

“I’ll give you that,” Violet agreed. “However, he is still male. Male and able to be sexually engaged. So maybe let’s at least get you something to swim in that’s cute, if still modest.”

“You’re not going to let this go, are you?”

“No, and if you don’t give in soon, I’m going to call Stella and get her involved, too.”

“Fiiiiiiiiine,” Camille said, stretching out the word into half acceptance and half groan. “Fine. We can go to the mall. But I’m not getting anything I’m uncomfortable wearing in public.”

“Nor would I want you to,” Violet replied. “I just want everyone to be

able to see how cute you really are.”

“Let’s just get this over with.” Camille hopped up from the bed and grabbed her keys. There were only a few days left until everyone departed for the beach. Better to start the hunt for a mutually satisfactory swimsuit now rather than get strong-armed into something when the deadline drew near.

\* \* \*

“I have to say, I’m impressed with you,” Angela commented as her little brother haphazardly tossed clothes into a duffle bag. “I never would have expected you to skip a week of training to go lounge at the beach.”

Shane avoided looking at his sister, who was perched on his bed, idly flipping through some of his books as she talked. Angela had shown up, uninvited and unwanted, half an hour ago to talk about spring break plans. He greatly suspected she’d come with the intention of forcing him into some activity he’d hate; however, she’d been beaten to the punch on that one.

“I don’t have much of a choice,” he grumbled, digging through the shallow dorm dresser drawers for extra socks. “They gave an open invite and my entire team jumped on it. Half of them are good friends with Team One anyway, the rest weren’t going to give up a free beach cabin.”

“That’s why I’m impressed. Shane from a year ago would have just trudged on with his training in spite of the fact that his whole team was going off to share an awesome experience. Being a captain has been good for you.”

A witty retort smashed against Shane’s teeth, begging to be let out, but he held it in. She didn’t need to know that he’d only appreciated the importance of team unity because it made them work together better in matches. She certainly didn’t need to be informed that Shane considered this a golden opportunity to gather information on the people he’d be most likely to face in the year’s final match. No, better she think this some silly attempt on his part to feel closer to his team.

“I’m half surprised you didn’t find a way to invite yourself along,” Shane replied, shifting the topic away from himself.

“I thought about it, but the only folks I know from your grade are you and Chad. He’s not going, and you’re a sourpuss, so it didn’t seem like it would be much fun.”

“What will you be doing with your time off then?”



“Cancun with some people from my own class,” she said with a shrug. “I do have my own friends, you know.”

“You’d never guess it from the way you hang around me,” Shane sniped.

“That’s just ’cause I like to make sure my widdle brother doesn’t get so tightly wound that he has a heart attack when he’s twenty.”

“I am not tightly wound,” Shane said, his neck tightening in annoyance. “I just don’t take life as flippantly as you.”

“Potato, potahto,” Angela said. “Speaking of, you got any grub? I have got a powerful hunger gnawing at my gut.”

Shane resisted the urge to try and hurl a lamp at her head. She’d just dodge it if he did, and then he’d be less one lamp. Instead he focused on the fact that the upside of this week would be seven magical days away from the annoying interruptions of his sister. For once, Shane couldn’t wait until classes were over.

\* \* \*

Nick was an hour away from Lander at a nondescript diner, eating a burger that he could only assume was the chef’s manifesto of hate against the world, when the girl walked in. Her long dark curls hung midway down a back wrapped in a red leather jacket that clung just the right amount of tightly to her chest. Her legs were sheathed in leather too, ostensibly a safety precaution since she’d ridden here on a motorcycle, but the way they hugged her noteworthy ass suggested an ulterior motive in their selection. She scanned the diner once, then walked to Nick’s booth and sat down.

“My goodness, I didn’t expect delivery from our top reproduction specialist,” Nick said by way of greeting.

“Please, you know this kind of stuff isn’t my area. Cybil did the work, but she had a bar mitzvah for her nephew so she asked me to make the drop.”

“How kind of you.”

The girl’s eyes twinkled as her mouth twisted into a smirk. “I couldn’t just pass up the chance to see the legendary Nicholas Campbell playing a good boy. Nice clothes, by the way.”

Nick bristled inwardly but kept any annoyance off his face. He was

playing a role; the fact that he looked so ridiculous spoke only to the fact that he had succeeded in creating an identity truly separate from his own.

“Eliza, much as I adore your body, your wit has never wowed me. How about we get down to business?”

“No need to be rude. Just because I’m the one girl in Vegas you haven’t been inside doesn’t mean you get a pass to be a dick. Especially not when I come bearing gifts.” She reached into her jacket and produced a thick white envelope. Carefully setting it on the table, she slid it over until it touched Nick’s plate.

Nick set down his burger and wiped his hands on the barely adequate napkin. He gently plucked up the envelope and popped it open by sliding his thumb along the seal. A quick survey of the contents seemed to satisfy him, as he laid it back on the table and returned to his meal. “Tell Cybil she’ll get the money within the week. Also let her know the work was exceptional, as always.”

“I’ll pass it along,” Eliza replied. “Why do you need that many fake IDs?”

“Think of it as my little contribution to a truly exceptional vacation.”

“Whatever, long as Cybil gets paid,” Eliza said with a shake of her head. “I think that concludes our business. Unless you want to introduce me to some of these mysterious fellow students of yours.”

“If that were the plan I wouldn’t have met you out here,” Nick pointed out. “Besides, you’d loathe them. Dreadfully dull compared to the company we keep.”

“I bet.” Eliza’s tone said she didn’t believe him, but her rising and heading out the door said she didn’t really care.

That was good; Nick had no intention of letting his real life and his Lander life mix. Much like the awful meal he was barely getting down, that particular combination of ingredients would produce a truly horrific flavor.

Roy might have known how to ride a motorcycle, but Hershel was less certain of both his balance and his ability to shrug off a collision. Thankfully, Nick was carpooling with Alex to the beach house, so he'd offered up his car as a substitute. Hershel's only concern as he cruised along the sun-ravaged highway was that this tiny automobile would offer scarcely more protection than a bike in a crash. Still, it wasn't dependent on him managing not to tip over, so for that much he was thankful.

It hadn't been a long trip from Lander campus to Colorado; despite waiting to say goodbye to Mary before departing, the afternoon sky was still bright as Hershel pulled into the gravel parking lot. It would be a few hours until the sizable building before him was open for business, but Hershel's father would be here already. He was always a man early to rise and begin the day's work. Hershel could have gotten here faster if he hadn't stopped so often, but something in his stomach seemed to be twisted up. This resulted in more bathroom and antacid breaks than necessary. He was here, at last. All he had to do was get out of the car and walk in the door.

An hour later the sun was drifting downward and Hershel was still sitting in Nick's car. There was no going back, not after making Roy miss class and keeping him confined for a week. His brother's wrath would be tremendous; the only saving grace would be making this work. Still, how many years had it been since he'd seen his father? Since he'd looked at the gigantic man with his own eyes? His mother had done a tremendous job of hiding Titan's Scandal from Hershel; it hadn't been until after Roy went to see him that they found out what happened. Until then, he hadn't understood why his father left. He'd only known how much he missed him.

It occurred to Hershel that if he didn't move soon, other cars might start showing up. There were a few hours of daylight left, but that didn't mean there couldn't be early-birds. The idea of having his reunion with other people around was enough to finally force Hershel from the fabric seat he'd been stalling for time in. He shut the door and locked the doors with the fob on the keychain.

No going back. Hershel began the long walk toward the front door.

\* \* \*

Nick let out a low whistle as he took in the layout of Alice's beach house. The ground floor was enormous, with a spectacular kitchen and living room that looked like it could comfortably seat twenty people, all with a good view of the enormous plasma television. Through a door on the side was a game room, two pool tables, and what appeared to be an old-school arcade game already visible from Nick's vantage point. Next to the restaurant-grade refrigerator was a single tap above a knob with twenty various beer logos on it. He'd seen a similar setup at some high-end bars, one tap able to pull from multiple routed kegs, but even in the decadence of Vegas Nick had never encountered such a system in a home.

"I'll say this about your dad, he knows how to build a party pad," Nick commented.

"My dad hates this kind of place," Alice corrected him. "Like I said, it mainly exists so he can loan it out to clients or businesses he is wooing."

"Consider me wooed."

"Wow, this place is huge!" Vince exclaimed, dragging his bag in through the door. Alex was only a few steps behind, his amazement apparent in the way his eyes flitted about the surroundings. The quartet had left earlier than the rest of the students to make sure they were there to greet arrivals. It had taken them longer than expected to arrive, though that was chiefly because Alex's car, while roomy, wasn't quite built for speed. They'd received more than a few middle-finger salutes as they pattered along the highway at fifty miles an hour, but they'd still managed to arrive intact.

"I recommend you guys stake out rooms on the second floor," Alice advised. "The third floor only has three bedrooms, and one of them is just a giant area filled with bunk beds. It dominates most of the floor, so the other rooms on three are pretty cozy."

"Don't you want to take first pick?" Alex asked politely.

"The one that's locked is mine," Alice replied. "I had the cleaning staff set it up for me. It's the only single bed in the place, so you'll forgive me for grabbing it."

"I think that's very fair, especially given how generous you are to let us all come here," Vince said. "Are there any rooms on the second floor with three beds? If we bunk together, we leave more options for the other guests."

"Up the stairs, third door to the right," Alice informed him.

“Not so fast there, bucko,” Nick said, holding up a hand to stop Vince’s forward progress. “First things first: I brought party favors.” He reached into his pocket and produced a crumpled white envelope. A brief flurry of activity from his nimble fingers sifted through its contents and suddenly three laminated cards were gripped in his digits. Nick extended the first to Alice, then handed one each to Vince and Alex.

“Fake ID’s?” Alex’s voice sounded as confused as Vince’s face looked.

“This isn’t a college town,” Nick explained. “This is a tourist destination. There’s always places we can go back home where the drinking age is determined by whether or not you can pay your tab. Here it’s different. Lots of places will enforce not only a drinking age, but a minimum age to enter. Now, I’m not saying you have to use them to get served alcohol, I’m just saying these ensure we can avail ourselves of any club or venue we find enticing.”

“Why does it have our real names?” Vince asked. “I admit I don’t know much about this stuff, but I thought you were supposed to use fake names.”

“Only if you’re an amateur. These are top quality. They’ll pass any test up to being run through the system by an actual police officer.” Nick might have beamed a bit as he spoke; he had helped Cybil refine her process a few years back and couldn’t help being proud of the results.

“Thanks, Nick,” Alice said. “These could lead to some real fun. I’d feel bad for the others, but this place is stocked well enough to keep up everyone comfortably buzzed for a month, let alone a week.”

“No need to feel bad for them, anyway,” Nick said. “In case you didn’t notice, I’ve got way more than three cards in my envelope.”

“Giant house, fake IDs, tons of alcohol.” Alex shook his head. “I didn’t ever expect I’d be having a spring break this awesome when I came to Lander.”

“Well, let’s get it started!” Nick declared, scooping up his own bag from the floor and racing toward the stairs. Vince and Alex were close on his heels, while Alice took her sweet time making the ascent. There was a whole week ahead of them, and she was in no need to hurry.

This was a time to relax and savor.



It didn't take Mary long to figure out that telepathy wasn't much help amidst college freshmen on spring break. This wasn't a matter of her being unable to hear their thoughts, or them being too convoluted to make sense of. No, the reason telepathy held no benefit is that everyone's mind centered chiefly around the same two subjects: alcohol and sex. Despite never having partaken in either, by the time her charges were gathering their individual coolers and heading toward the water, Mary was thoroughly sick of both topics.

"Cameron!" Chad barked to her right. "One cooler per person."

The alcohol-ability-based freshman looked at his chaperone with utter dejection, then placed two of three coolers he'd been trying to haul off back on the ground. Candi scooped one of them up and patted him on the back. It seemed every class had a few sober kids to act as booze mules for the heavy drinkers. Walter and Gale weren't far behind, the bespectacled boy trying and failing to swill down beer as though he drank it frequently. Those were the only freshmen Mary recognized; the remaining were a blur of faces she knew from below ground but couldn't have put names to without referencing a student handbook. Chad, however, had no such issues.

"Kelly! Buddy system is not optional, pair with a group. Jim! Pull your trunks up. If you want to strip at least wait until everyone is too drunk to care."

"How do you do that?"

"Perfect memory," Chad said, his eyes still scanning the departing freshmen for infraction. "I always memorize the names of everyone in the HCP at the beginning of the year."

"Why?"

Chad shrugged. "Just seemed like something that might come in useful."

"Oh," Mary said. "Has it?"

"Occasionally. Not as often as I'd expected," Chad admitted. "Jim! I am not going to warn you again."

A sullen-looking boy with dark hair pulled his swimsuit up then began moving with increasing speed toward the river.

“Were you guys this bad last year?”

“Probably, although Angela and Ben were somewhat less strict with us.”

“Should we let up a little then?”

“I was planning on it once we actually got on the river. I wanted to set a firm standard initially and then enforce it only as needed through the rest of the trip,” Chad explained. “As long as they know we’re here to keep them in line, we probably won’t have to.”

“You sound like you have practice at this.”

“None at all; Angela gave me some pointers.”

Mary tilted her head in surprise. “That doesn’t really seem like her management style.”

“It isn’t. This is the one she thought would work best for me.” Chad bent over and grabbed a cooler of his own. “I’ll take the point position if you want to follow at the rear in case of stragglers.”

“Sounds like a plan. You thinking of drinking?” Mary motioned to the cooler in his hand.

“No, but I might want a water. Besides, I’m sure some of the more daring students will loot my alcohol when they think I’m not looking.” Mary wasn’t quite sure, but she thought she saw the outline of a smile on Chad’s well-defined face. Not for the first time, she wished she could read the mind behind her inscrutable classmate. Wishing did no good, so instead she grabbed a tube and followed him down to where the freshmen were already splashing noisily into the gentle current.

\* \* \*

Mr. Transport arrived at the doorstep with a bouquet of flowers freshly picked from a remote hill in Norway. It was the sort of thing that would have seemed overeager if he’d planned on telling his date where they were procured; however, without context they merely seemed like a lovely choice from the local florist.

His suit, always pressed and fitted, was complimented with an electric



blue tie rather than his usual black one. It presented a jauntier image, or at least that's what the salesman had convinced him. Mr. Transport was an expert on many things: geography, Australian wine, home-brewed beer, munitions, and the works of Isaac Asimov to name a few. Sadly, fashion and dating were two subjects lacking in his repertoire. He was quite fortunate, in as much as he was out of practice pitching woo, the woman he was romancing was out of practice in receiving it.

Ms. Daniels answered the door by the third knock, her hair carefully curled and a turquoise dress draped over her figure. It didn't hide her body entirely, and while time and childbirth had certainly softened the once sleek frame of the Southern belle, she'd logged enough time on the treadmill to keep the ultimate ravages of age at bay.

"On time as always," Ms. Daniels said as a greeting.

"You look lovely tonight, Sally," Mr. Transport said, handing over his meager offering of flora.

"I suppose you look a bit dashing yourself. I like your tie."

Mr. Transport felt a goofy smile dance across his face. It was embarrassing, but his life had been cut off from normality in his early twenties, so he'd never evolved past this phase of dating. He still got flustered and cheerful by simple compliments. Unbeknownst to him, it was one of the qualities Sally Daniels found endearing.

The two had been on three dates since Mr. Transport found the gumption to ask her out, his schedule rarely meshing along with her own. Spring break offered a rare opportunity; with his charges all off on various vacations, Mr. Transport only had his other company duties to attend to, ones which were infrequent and unpredictable. They had resolved to use this opportunity for a prolonged dating session, one to determine if they would grow sick on each other's company or more enamored with it. It was a somewhat clinical approach to the idea of love, but both had tight schedules and little time to piss away on an endeavor that would ultimately culminate in failure.

"Come on in," Sally said, stepping to the side. "I thought we could have a drink and catch up before dinner."

Mr. Transport stepped inside happily, goofy grin still firmly plastered in place.

The interior of the building had an industrial feel to it. The tables were metal, the stools seemed cobbled together from lead pipes and wood. Tin sheeting adorned the walls, hunks of it cut away to make room for doorways and bars. Amidst the rough décor there were only still hints as to this establishment's true purpose. Colorful lights ran along nearly every surface, unlit but still noticeable to the keen eye. An enormous slab of wood elevated an open area three inches up from the concrete floor, giant speakers near it almost, but not quite, concealed from view. The truly experienced partier would notice a few holes drilled in the upper part of the sheeting just above the wooden slab, a perfect size for a fog machine to spray its contents on the area below. It was a contrast of joy and efficiency, of work and play. It had definitely been constructed by Hershel and Roy's father.

Hershel took all this in, comparing it to Roy's memory from so many years ago and discovering more similarities than differences. Roy had made the mistake of coming at night; so much of the fine detail had escaped his attention. The place had been more distracting, and what he'd seen more distressing. This time he knew what he was walking into, and he could handle it. Seeing his father, however, Hershel was less confident in that regard. He really didn't know what his first words would be to the man who had left them.

It didn't take long to find out. As Hershel stood by the entrance, a large man stepped out from one of the doorways to the back. He was close to seven feet tall, his arms thicker than a bodybuilder's legs, and his legs looked closer related to steel beams than human limbs. A dark beard was trimmed close so as to still show off his impressive jaw line and handsome face. In each hand he carried a silver keg, presumably full, although one wouldn't have known that from the ease with which he slung them around.

Hershel found his breathing was no longer functional and his ability to keep his knees steady had all but vanished. It had been over a decade since he'd seen this man through anything but Roy's memory, yet he was unmistakable. This giant could only be Titan, the unstoppable monster who left all but the most powerful criminals trembling at the mention of his name. Hershel cleared his throat accidentally as he tried to suck in air and regain some semblance of mental balance.

The giant turned his head toward the sound and froze. A riotous clanking filled the air as the kegs clattered to the ground, gathering dents and ensuring that any beer inside would be undrinkable for days. It took less than five sizable strides for him to cross the room, stopping only a few inches from Hershel's still somewhat shaky form. His father laid an enormous hand on each of Hershel's shoulders and stared down at the boy, his face a tempest of emotions, each fighting for the right to be showcased. A single word escaped his mouth, deep and rich as a jazz singer and dripping with just as much emotion.

“Son.”

Hershel reared back and struck his father in the jaw with all the strength he had. It was a futile gesture: even most Heroes couldn't put down this powerhouse. Still, sometime later, when Roy finally regained control of the body, he would look back on this memory and, despite all the other negative emotions that would be rolling through him at the time, feel a tremendous sense of brotherly pride.

\* \* \*

It didn't take long for the quiet tranquility of Alice's beach house to be shattered by a slew of arrivals. Stella, Violet, Thomas, and Camille were the first ones to show up after the prep team. With the exception of Camille, everyone was at least partially intoxicated. It seemed Stella had wanted to pre-game and Violet had jumped on the idea, cajoling Thomas into at least partial participation. By the time they'd finally gotten the three girls set up in a room, Will, Jill, Julia, and Sasha had arrived. Sasha was uncharacteristically silent, avoiding conversation and even eye contact with anyone besides Julia. It didn't take a genius to figure out she'd been talked into coming and was clearly regretting it. For her part, Camille went out of her way to greet the speedy girl and welcome her to the event. If anything, this only seemed to make Sasha retract further into her shell.

As the day wore on, more groups showed up at the door. Shane, Rich, Adam, Britney, and Amber all carpooled together. Selena and Tiffani were the last arrivals, appearing a few minutes after two. It was bedlam at first as people jockeyed to find open rooms with their friends, eventually culminating in the last folks hunkering down in the open bunk bed room that dominated most of the third floor. It was riotous but cheerful in spirit. Those intent on partying realized the odds of them making it to the appropriate bed were slim, and those intent on sobriety assumed they'd be more capable of getting back

to their assigned space. By the time four in the afternoon appeared on the kitchen's clock a variety of activities had begun.

There was a pool tournament at one of the billiards tables, complete with a tiered bracket system that would be impossible to maintain once a true zenith of intoxication was reached. Violet had organized a Power Hour in the living room, insistent that by week's end they all be capable of completing a Bicentennial Club. Vince had started a beach volleyball game out in the sand; currently he and Thomas were two points up on the team of Shane and Will. Some of the girls were sitting on the deck, catcalling their male classmates and enjoying margaritas made from an actual drum-style machine rather than a blender and ice. Shockingly, it was Nick and Camille who were in the kitchen, preparing nachos, bacon sandwiches, and other assorted foods designed to satisfy munchies and offer at least some relief from the ravages of alcohol.

It was hectic, it was disorganized, it was highly irresponsible. It was exactly what everyone needed.

## 131.

“Drink this,” Hershel’s father said, placing a clear glass filled by a dull yellow liquid in front of him. “It will make your hand feel better.” He moved into the booth opposite his son and slid the concoction forward gently. Hershel reached for it with his right hand, winced, and switched to his left. It turned out that just because you couldn’t hurt someone with your punch didn’t mean their jaw couldn’t still injure the small bones in your hands. It would mend eventually; one trade with Roy and Hershel would be pain free. That would have to wait, unfortunately. Which reminded him...

“There’s no whiskey in this, is there?”

“Whiskey?”

“Yeah, whiskey.”

Hershel’s father shook his head. “Tequila, a few mixers, and a splash of vodka, but no whiskey.”

“Good.” Hershel took two oversized mouthfuls and gulped them down before lowering the glass. He found his father staring at him with an expression of curiosity.

“Whiskey makes you change now, right? After that weird procedure it doesn’t just happen unwanted; you set up a chemical trigger.”

“I see Mom has kept you up to speed.”

“Second year HCP, living as a Super, she even told me about your girlfriend. Of course, nothing she mentioned would explain why you felt the need to drive all the way out here and take a swing at me.”

“The punch wasn’t planned,” Hershel said, though he pointedly avoided anything that would make it sound like he was sorry. “I came out here for a different reason. Roy needs help.”

His father tilted his head and motioned for Hershel to continue, so he laid everything on the table. The wall he’d hit, the inability to break through, the growing frustration as well as the slowly-increasing gap between Roy and the others’ capabilities.

“So Roy is stuck at about, what, eight hundred pounds per arm you said?”

Hershel nodded, finishing off the remainder of his drink. His father had been right; it had indeed lessened the pain in his hand.

“Well, son, it seems to me-”

“Hershel.”

“What was that?”

“Hershel. That’s my name. Let’s stay away from familial terms, okay? You’re Owen, I’m Hershel, Roy is Roy.”

“Fine,” Owen Daniels said after a brief pause. “I guess I deserve that. Anyway, Hershel, it seems to me you’ve got a pretty big problem. Curling just under a ton would get you through a lot of fights and manual labor jobs, but I’m afraid it won’t cut it if you want to be a Hero.”

“I know that.”

“No, you only suspected it. If you knew it then you would have drawn up a resignation in case I said I couldn’t help. Deep down you’re hoping that with enough skill maybe this wall won’t matter, that there will be another method that will keep Roy as a viable candidate. I’m crushing that delusion right now. Other Supers can get by without massive strength, but they have different talents to compensate. Not ones like us. We hit the living shit out of things, and if we can’t hit hard enough to knock them down then all we are is a liability to our teams. Do you understand?”

“Yes.”

“Good.” Owen rose from the table and walked over to the bar with more grace than a man his size had any right to possess. He grabbed a full bottle and dumped a few pours of alcohol into a glass tumbler, then tossed in a trio of ice cubes. He came back and sat down, setting the brown drink carefully in front of him. He took a gentle sip to assess, and from the pleasure on his face, the alcohol seemed to meet his requirements.

“Good,” Owen repeated. “Because I didn’t just say all that to bum you out. I don’t want you thinking that all hope is lost, but I do feel that it’s important you keep your expectations realistic. That said, I can help you past this issue, and teach you how to deal with others of its kind that will eventually surface.”

“How? How can I do it?”

Owen held up a finger. “Not so fast. This isn’t going to be easy, and it isn’t going to be quick. I’m willing to help, but I want you to seriously commit to undertaking this training. I’ll take shit as your father, not as your teacher.”

“I’m sure Roy will-”

“We’ll deal with Roy later. I’m talking to Hershel right now. Roy isn’t some abstract entity, he’s a part of you. So if I’m going to do this, I want to hear you tell me you’ll do whatever it takes.”

Hershel slowly moved his head up and down. “If it will help Roy, I’ll do whatever I can.”

“Good.” Owen slid the glass of dark liquor across the table. Even from a distance, Hershel immediately recognized the familiar odor that wafted up from its depths. “Now drink that.”

“I can’t. That will turn me into Roy.”

“That’s the point,” Owen said, looking unflinchingly at his son.

“That’s not a good idea,” Hershel explained. “If I turn now, Roy will just storm out of here. We need to lay out a plan and outline how to help him before there’s a shot at him playing along.”

“No.”

“No?”

“No. You came to me, not vice versa. So I’m not proving myself to you. I know how to fix your problem. You obviously believe that, or you wouldn’t be here. Roy needs to believe that, too. This isn’t a case of fixing the issue and making him believe, it’s a case of him needing to believe in order to fix the issue.”

“I’m not sure he’ll listen,” Hershel said, his uncertainty written across his face.

“I promise, I won’t let Roy leave here. If nothing else, I’ll subdue him until you turn back,” Owen said.

Hershel had zero doubt that he could do it, too. There were many things that had been called into question regarding his father over the year, but the man’s awe-inspiring strength was not one of them. Still, the prospect of shifting right now seemed unwise. In the end, it didn’t feel like he really

had a choice. He'd come here to find a solution, and now there was one sitting in front of him. The only thing standing in the way of helping Roy was... Roy. Hershel wanted to help, but this was as far as he could take things by himself. The rest was up to his brother.

In a single, practiced motion, Hershel grabbed the glass and emptied its contents down his throat. He set it back on the table and looked at his father one last time before his consciousness was gone.

“Good luck.”



## 132.

Nick, Vince, and Will sat on the house's deck, watching the low moon reflect off the lapping ocean waters. Nick was nursing a beer while the other two sipped soda. Behind them the house gave off a dull roar of constant noise. The pre-gaming had led to its eventual outcome, a localized festival of intoxication. Thankfully, they'd been able to corral most people into eating dinner, even though it had been akin to herding mosquitoes as they darted from one target of interest to another. The three were not the only ones with some sobriety, the others of their ilk merely sought sanctuary in different locations.

"Good thing Alice doesn't have neighbors," Will pointed out as the music increased in volume. The farthest house from them was a good six-minute walk, visible but not so close that they could make out details. It seems that Charles Adair enjoyed his space when purchasing an abode.

"Much louder and I wouldn't be shocked if the police are called anyway," Vince said.

"Nah. Even if they were home, which they aren't, it's spring break. As long as nothing is on fire and no one is dying, a little noise is low on the cops' priority list," Nick countered. "Admittedly, we've got a good party going."

"I'm surprised you're out here with us," Vince said. "You like this kind of thing."

"I do, but burning yourself out on day one is a rookie mistake. This is a marathon. If you go too hard too fast you'll find yourself unable to function by day three. The trick is to ease your liver into it. Besides, it's not even eight yet. I've got a lot of night left to burn."

"The way they're going, I'd be surprised if they made it past ten," Will pointed out.

"Guess you didn't see the pantry full of Red Bull then, did you?"

"No. No, I did not."

"You know, I think this is really cool," Vince said suddenly.

"Yes, Vince, an enormous beach house stocked with friends and alcohol definitely qualifies as at least pretty cool."

“No, not that. I mean, that is great, but I was talking about how many of our classmates came to join us.”

“It was a hard offer to resist,” Will said.

“I know, but... I was just thinking about the beginning of the year. We were so worried about how everyone would react to us. We even got warned that some people would treat us like pariahs and hate us. Yet less than a year later, here we are. All drinking and vacationing together. No one really cares that we used to be Powered. We’re all just students trying to get through this together. That’s what I think is great.”

Nick and Will exchanged glances. Despite specializing in different areas, they were easily the smartest members of their class, and as such they’d both seen what Vince couldn’t. Some of the camaraderie was based on genuine friendship: people like Will or Thomas or Violet had all gone out of their way to show they cared more about who the Melbrook residents were than what they had been. That was far from the case with everyone. Many of the others regarded them as a science fair experiment that had encroached into their everyday lives. The only thing that preserved civility was a simple lack of concern. Every HCP student had their own fears and challenges to deal with. Right now they were too preoccupied with their own advancement to start looking at each other as genuine competitors. As the slots grew fewer, that would change, and those undertones of hate would be sure to surface. They were living in an illusion of acceptance, and both boys knew it.

“It is pretty impressive,” Will agreed.

“True. Sort of gives you hope for the world,” Nick added.

Sooner or later people would show themselves for what they were. Still, if Vince was lucky enough to believe he was surrounded by friends, there was no need to shatter his delusion. For now, at least, he could be happy.

\* \* \*

“So far, so good,” Mary said.

“No one is dead, we’ve hydrated them enough to avoid alcohol poisoning, and the tents are up without anything being lit on fire,” Chad recounted.

“So far,” Mary pointed out.

“So far,” Chad agreed.

The two were having a brief respite around one of the unattended fires that had earlier been used for roasting hot dogs and marshmallows. The drunken teens had lost interest once their stomachs were full, choosing instead to chase the twin pleasures of booze and members of the opposite sex in swimsuits. Chad had nonchalantly hung a trash bag filled with condoms from a mirror on the bus and both chaperones were making a point of being nowhere near it. The point wasn't to embarrass anyone, it was just to make sure no one had to drop out of HCP due to pregnancy.

"I was expecting worse," Mary said after a few minutes of listening to the fire crackle.

"We were a little worse," Chad said. "Roy and Stella had already had a scuffle by now. Not to mention Gilbert finding it exceedingly funny to teleport off with girls' tops."

"I am just so very glad I wasn't here for that."

Chad showed a rare smile, the firelight almost reflecting off the gleaming veneer of his teeth. "It didn't last long. After he snagged Britney and Tiffani's tops, Angela got involved. Gilbert was the model of behavior for the rest of the trip."

"That girl is something else. I've never even seen her fight, but I still feel like she'd mop the floor with me," Mary said.

"It wouldn't be that bad, but you would lose. Angela is quite an exceptional warrior."

"Sounds like you admire her," Mary said carefully.

"Very much so. I'm lucky she's taken an interest in me and helped me improve my own skills. I doubt I would have managed so much growth over this year if not for her."

"She's quite pretty, too," Mary pointed out.

"That she is," Chad agreed. His voice sounded almost... wistful? It was hard to tell with him, he was almost always so detached in his mannerisms. "Anyway, in spite of our antics, she ran a tight ship during our time here. Good thing, too; I'm truly amazed no one managed to hurt themselves."

"After today I can believe it. Weird that they don't send a healer along on these trips," Mary said.

“You think so?”

“Don’t you?”

“To be honest, I thought it was intentional. A way to remind us that in the outside world things can’t automatically be mended, be they bodies or property. It forces them to live with the consequences of their choices, even if only for a week.”

“Or the school’s healers demanded they be allowed this week off,” Mary suggested.

Chad looked back at her with another thin smile. “I suppose that makes sense, too.”

### 133.

Three tables were overturned, two more were broken beyond repair, and a sizable dent was visible in one of the walls, but Roy had finally been subdued. Owen held his still weakly-struggling son in a headlock from behind, giving him enough air to stay conscious but not so much that he would get ideas of starting back up. While Owen was too resilient to be hurt by anything Roy could do, the bar was not. As it was, Roy's first assault would cost a fair amount to fix.

"Got that out of your system?" Owen asked calmly.

"Let me go, fucker! I'm leaving!" Roy's efforts redoubled, his muscular form clawing and swinging wildly at his captor. Not that it mattered; he might as well have been a cloud attacking a statue for all the good it did. Owen let him kick about for a few seconds before tightening his grip and cutting off Roy's air. He loosened it again once he felt his son's limbs begin to slacken.

"Sorry, can't do that," Owen replied once Roy's grunting had grown quiet. "I promised Hershel I wouldn't let you leave."

"Fuck... Hershel," Roy wheezed out in ragged gasps. "Fuck...ing... traitor."

"He thought you might feel that way. To be honest I assumed he was overreacting. I suppose I should have known better."

This time Roy had no response; he merely hung there sullenly.

"So you think Hershel betrayed you, even though he only did this because you were too proud to admit you were out of options. Even though I saw his car arrive over an hour before he worked up the nerve to come in here, and had to do I can only imagine what to find the gumption to drive out in the first place."

"Stupid... ass...hole."

"Yes, Roy, your brother who came out here on his spring break, risked his relationship with you, and confronted a man he hadn't seen in over a decade all to help his brother is a stupid asshole." Owen clicked his tongue against his teeth, and Roy's mind swirled back to childhood, remembering hearing the sound whenever his father was scolding one of them. "You might

be the one who got the enhanced muscles, but Hershel is undoubtedly the stronger of you two.”

“Kiss... my... ass.”

“Fine, smart guy, then tell me one thing. If Hershel is so wrong for coming to see me, if you really don’t need my help, then why are you hanging here helpless? I’m barely using any strength, and those punches you threw at me were worthless. I’m not saying you could take me on, even in the best of scenarios, but you’ve been in the HCP for almost two years now. You should be much stronger than this. So why aren’t you?”

Roy hung there quietly, neither words nor actions able to fully capture the amount of hatred he felt for his father at uttering that damned piece of truth.

“No answer to that one? My my, so it seems Hershel might have had some good reason for doing this after all. I can tell you why you’re weak, Roy. I can tell you why, and I can show you how to get back on the right path. Or, you can keep struggling like a child and wait until you turn back into Hershel, at which point I’ll tell him no luck. Son or not, I will not help a Super who can’t control his emotions get stronger. That just puts other people in danger down the line. So it’s your choice. Stow the violence and listen, or hang here until your best shot at being a Hero swirls down the crapper.”

There was a period of motionlessness from Roy then he slowly lifted his right arm. For an instant Owen thought his son would hurl a waste of a punch, but instead Roy brought it down in two swift taps on Owen’s elbow. It was their signal for giving up, a simple tap-out. Owen released his grip and Roy slid to the floor. He went to rub his throat, but stopped before his hand was halfway there. Instead he walked over to one of the non-damaged tables, sat down roughly, and looked over at his father. “Talk.”

It wasn’t great manners, but it was progress. “You want a beer before we get started?”

“Fuck, yes.”

Owen filled two mugs with dark ale and joined his son. His eyes flitted to the clock; he’d need to open up pretty soon and Roy wouldn’t want to be here when that happened. Best to get on with this.

“First, a couple of conditions. You two are going to spend the rest of your break here, with me. This will require training, and I have the tools and

experience to make sure it's done right. Hershel is already committed to doing whatever is needed, but can you handle that?"

Roy nodded stiffly and took a deep drink from his mug.

"Good. Second, you don't have to like me or forgive me; however, you will obey me while here. You might consider me a shitty dad but it doesn't change the fact that I was a very capable Hero. This is only a week; we don't have time for arguments and backtalk."

Roy nodded again.

"Third, you are going to stay at a hotel a few miles up the road, which I will be paying for. We'll train during the day, the nights are yours, but you should stay away from here. This is a legitimate bar and we don't allow underage kids in, even if they are the owner's son."

Roy snorted into his beer at the word "legitimate," however he gave a final curt bob of his head to signify acceptance.

Owen took a swig of his own drink and checked the clock again. "Glad we got that out of the way. Have Hershel here at seven in the morning, sharp. Tell him to skip breakfast, too. He'll be glad he did."

"That's it?" Roy said gruffly. "All that talk about answers and you're just telling me to send Hershel back in the morning? How the hell does that help me?"

Owen stared back at the wild-eyed young man and tried to picture the feisty little boy he'd once been. It wasn't hard; in many ways Roy had never really grown up. Owen supposed a fair part of that might be his fault. It was time to start remedying that.

"Condition number two, obey my orders," Owen said. "If you don't think I've lived up to my part by the end of tomorrow then you are free to leave. Until then, our bargain is still valid. Hershel. Here. Seven. Understand?"

"Understand." Roy spat the word, killed off the rest of his beer, and stormed out the door.

Owen watched him go with a heavy heart. There was so much anger in his sons: one wore it on the outside and the other kept it hidden away, but it was there nonetheless. What's worse, he was certain that he was the root cause of it for both of them. Some days he wished there was a Super with the

power to travel through time, someone who could help him right just a few of the many things he'd done wrong. Sadly, that was still in the realm of the impossible. All he could do now was try his best to fix what had been broken. That process started tomorrow.

Seven in the morning. Sharp.



## 134.

To say that Hershel was coated in sweat would give the impression that his perspiration had settled across his skin like a coating, merely encompassing him then ceasing its advancement. This image would do a great disservice to the amount of moisture being churned out by his body. To say he was dripping, that his coating was continually being shed and replaced, that would be far more accurate.

Hershel dripped along a track in the bar's backyard as the early sun moved upward through the sky. Track was a generous term; really it was more a semi-circular rut that had been worn in the soft dirt by countless traversals. A metal fence hid his shame, as well as a vast array of workout equipment, from the view of the world. The only witness to his exhausted stumbling was Owen Daniels, standing near the bar's entrance with an unreadable expression on his face. Hershel had no idea why he was being made to run in laps; he'd shown up as instructed, been handed some exercise clothing, and been told to run until he was told to stop. By this point he was less "running" than he was "plodding" but he continued moving forward nonetheless.

After thirty minutes, Hershel was sure his legs would give out, yet it turned out he was able to conjure another five minutes of effort from his body before it fell to the ground and began to dry-heave. At least he understood why Owen had told him to skip breakfast.

"That's enough running," Owen instructed. "Take a ten minute break and we'll move on to weights."

"Why?" Hershel asked once his mouth was no longer occupied with responding to his stomach's futile evacuation attempts. "Why am I training instead of Roy?"

In response, Owen plucked a water bottle from his side and brought it over to Hershel. Hershel took it in small sips; he knew enough about working out to know that guzzling it would just result in his body reactivating its attempts at purging.

"What do you think your power is?" Owen asked once Hershel had eventually managed to drain the bottle.

"I'm a shifter," Hershel replied. "They classified me when I was five."

“Oh? You know any other shifters whose personalities are totally altered when they change? I’m not talking an influx of animal instinct or an increase in aggression, but a total change in who they are and how they act. The way you and Roy are.”

Hershel thought back carefully. “Not that I can recall. Dean Blaine once told us that the classifications were just general terms, that every Super and Powered was their own entity with their own unique traits. Maybe the mental change is just part of mine.”

Owen nodded. “You’re not wrong, but you’re not right either.”

“I don’t understand.”

“Clearly,” Owen said, his gaze unwavering as he looked at his son with some mixture of worry and determination. “Every Super is different, even if it’s in very small ways. That part was right.”

“So what was wrong?”

“You’re not a shifter.” Owen took the empty water bottle from his son’s hands. “That’s ten minutes. We’re moving on to weights.”

“But-”

“Weights.” Owen walked toward the cluster of reinforced benches without casting so much as a glance to see if his son was following. Hershel struggled to his feet and followed along. It seemed that whatever Owen knew, he would only tell when he was ready. Until that time came, all Hershel could do was keep his promise and do as he was told. He just hoped his body would hold out as long as his determination.

\* \* \*

Vince came in from a morning run to find the house still largely silent, though Stella’s intermittent snores could be heard from the billiards room. She had found the floor exceptionally comfortable the night before and shifted to steel so no one could easily carry her back to bed. Like the rest of the house, she was still asleep. Even those who’d stayed sober were taking the opportunity to sleep in a bit, with the obvious exception of Vince. He’d been an early riser for as long as he could remember; it was an important aspect of being a homeless wanderer. The last thing you wanted was for someone to come upon you unconscious and defenseless. The need was so deeply ingrained that even in a place like this he couldn’t shake it.

A shower sounded good to Vince, but breakfast sounded better. He decided to whip up a quick meal of eggs before washing off. Surveying the fridge, he found them in no short supply, so he cracked six in a bowl, added seasoning, and tossed them in a pan. The smells might wake some of the others, and he wanted to have enough to share if they came down. If they didn't then he would stick the leftovers in the fridge and the first risers could help themselves. Vince was so intent on scraping his culinary task around the pan that he didn't notice the presence behind him until it spoke up.

"Morning." It was a familiar voice, one Vince probably could have picked out of an audible lineup. The tone and inflection it was sporting, those were of a variety he hadn't heard in a long while.

"Good morning, Sasha," Vince said. He turned around briefly and flashed her a small smile. She seemed unusually awkward, standing there in PJ pants and t-shirt, trying not to show how uncomfortable she felt. "I'm making extra eggs if you want any."

"No, thank you. I'm not really hungry." Both of them fell silent as the sound of sizzling filled the room, punctuated occasionally by a noise contribution from Stella.

"I wanted to talk about what happened in the match," Sasha blurted out.

"Shouldn't that be something you talk to Camille about?" Vince worked hard to keep his voice controlled. He reminded himself for the umpteenth time that it had been a fight, and sometimes people lost control in those types of situations. That was a lesson he'd acquired firsthand. She clearly felt bad; she didn't need him to add more guilt.

"I will," Sasha promised. "I wanted to talk to you first. Come on, you know I don't normally get up this early."

"That's true. I usually had to rouse you with promises of food." Later in the relationship he'd had other methods of waking her; however, that wasn't a healthy thought to deal with at the moment.

"Exactly. I woke up early so I could tell you something while it was just us. The reason I lost it on Camille. It's because I'm jealous of her."

Vince turned from the eggs and gazed at his ex-girlfriend with a confused look. "Jealous?"

“Yeah, jealous,” Sasha replied. “It’s obvious you two have grown closer over the year, and even if it isn’t romantic in nature, every time I see you together I just... I’m jealous, okay? I wish I was the one getting to spend all the time with you, and all of that built up emotion just got out of control.”

“Sasha, you broke up with me,” Vince said slowly. “You made it clear you didn’t want anything to do with me.”

“Which is why I came down here to make it clear that I was wrong. I know how you are, so I’m not going to beat around the bush. I want to be together again. Boyfriend and girlfriend, all that stuff. This is probably a surprise to you, so I’m not asking for an answer right away. Take some time and think about it. I’ll be around whenever you figure out how you feel about the idea.”

Vince heard a slight gust of air and knew if he turned around Sasha would be gone. She’d no doubt dashed back to her room to hide after such a display of vulnerability. For his part, Vince wasn’t sure how to feel. He hadn’t been prepared for that, and had no idea what he should say back to her. There was no question he missed her; however, as time had worn on, he couldn’t help but wonder if their breakup might not have been for the best. Sasha was right, he needed to think about it.

The eggs went into a Tupperware container and were thrust into the fridge. Vince’s appetite had suddenly receded.

## 135.

“You’ve learned some new tricks,” Miriam Taylor commented, carefully slicing off another piece of chicken breast. She didn’t know how, but the chef had managed to impart a surprising amount of moisture and flavor without overwhelming the bird’s base taste. The asparagus side dish complimented things nicely, as did the squash puree.

“I have a bit of free time on weekends,” Dean Blaine said, beginning work on his own entrée. “It gives me time to experiment with new recipes I’ve read about.”

“Well, a few more meals like this and I just might forget about you sending off my son over break.”

“I shall endeavor to do my best.” Dean Blaine was visiting Miriam as a poor substitute for the son she’d expected. So far they’d taken in two plays and a museum, with plenty of time left for whatever other activities she could conceive of. She was clearly punishing him; however, it could have been worse, so at least Dean Blaine knew she understood. It would be hard for her not to, after all; despite being perfectly human, most of her social group in college had been members of the HCP.

“I’ll hold you to that,” Miriam replied. “This is impressive. If I didn’t know better I’d swear you’ve been taking lessons from...” Her voice pattered off as her words caught up with what she’d intended to say.

“He was an amazing cook,” Dean Blaine agreed. They’d avoided the elephant in the room so far, but he saw no point in continuing to do so now that she’d tripped over its trunk. “Of course, with his power it’s hard to know how much was actual skill and how much was him fiddling around.”

“You said ‘was’ an amazing cook. So that means it’s not true, right? He didn’t raise that boy in Chad’s class. He isn’t... he hasn’t come back.” Miriam’s knife scraped loudly against the plate as her hand gave way to a slight tremor.

“All we have is a story of a homeless man with a watch,” Dean Blaine assured her. “It’s strange, but it’s hardly unexplainable. Besides, the boy he acted as a father to has no memory of him ever using an ability. We are as certain as we can be that Globe is still an unfortunate piece of the past and nothing more.”

“Thank God,” Miriam said, steadying herself with some effort. “I don’t know how Chad would handle it; he is already so preoccupied with his father. If Globe hadn’t died, I fear my son would have become obsessed with hunting him rather than emulating Joshua.”

“I have faith he would have been put on a healthier path.” Dean Blaine knew that despite her occasional trepidation, Miriam was not a woman easily stopped, especially where her son was concerned. “But all of this is for nothing. Chad is a well-adjusted, if overly focused, young man, and Globe is dead in the ground where he deserves to be.”

“All these years, and that thought is still strange to me,” Miriam admitted. “Even knowing he killed my husband, even seeing the videos... Joshua almost missed Chad’s birth, you know. He and Globe got tangled up a few miles from the city with a criminal that could turn into swarms of bugs. By the time it was resolved there was so little time left, and Shimmerpath was with the rest of the team on another assignment. It was thanks to Globe that Joshua made it in time. He ignored all manner of protocol to do it, but he made it happen.”

“He would have done anything for Joshua. They were best friends since freshman year,” Dean Blaine said.

Miriam nodded and took another bite of her food. “We asked him to be Chad’s godfather, but he talked us out of it. He said it should be someone not on the team, someone who wasn’t a Hero. That way, if anything really bad happened, Chad would have someone whose life wasn’t always at risk. He wanted to do it, you could see it in his eyes. He just refused to put his desires over what was best for our son. That’s the man who killed my husband.” She looked up at him, not asking the question she’d grilled him with so many times over the years. Wasn’t there something he knew, some tidbit to give clarity on what had happened?

Dean Blaine said nothing. He had nothing he could say. It didn’t make sense to him either. It never had, probably never would. The footage was there, grainy though it was. Several different security cameras from nearby businesses had captured the two team members’ confrontation. Intra had allegedly discovered that Globe was secretly working with a local mafia boss and had attempted to talk to him about it. Globe had become aggressive, and in the ensuing battle Intra managed to sever Globe’s arm. Globe, unfortunately, was able to leave his best friend as nothing more than a corpse in the street. This had all been explained by their teammates later on. One

could see the series of actions on the video, but not hear the words. Dean Blaine would have given damn near anything to know what those two said to one another. He was far from the only one.

“This classmate of Chad’s, the one who had Globe’s watch, what sort of person is he?” Miriam asked, bringing Dean Blaine out of his internal reverie.

“Kind,” Dean Blaine replied after some thought. “Kind, and surprisingly gentle, given the nature of his power. He is quite dedicated to all of his friends, and he seems to be a bit ignorant of people’s social wiles. Also, he’s positively dense when it comes to women.”

“Sounds like he and Chad would get along,” Miriam noted. She looked up at Dean Blaine and locked eyes with him. “He also sounds a lot like I’d expect a child raised by Globe, by the Globe I knew, to be.”

“Good men are in short supply in our world, but they do exist,” Dean Blaine countered. “All it would take is one of them to raise a boy like that.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Miriam said, temporarily retreating. “Let’s move onto more pleasant topics. There’s a modern art show opening tomorrow night.”

Dean Blaine suppressed a groan. He loathed the modern stuff, but it was a small price to pay for making Miriam happy. Besides, there would probably be decent wine there.

## 136.

By the time Owen called the first day to an end, Hershel was barely able to stand. Weights, running, jumping, and a variety of aerobic workouts had been spread out through the day. It was enough to make him long for that first day of working out under Coach George. Despite his body's constant protests, Hershel had stumbled on, the quality of his movements gradually deteriorating until even standing was a concentrated effort. He couldn't remember ever feeling this weak or worn down. Owen had literally pushed him to the end of his limits several times, always backing off just enough to keep him from losing consciousness. He gulped down a few sips of water as he watched the afternoon sun on its downward trek toward the horizon.

Owen emerged from the inside of the bar holding a grey plastic water bottle, the kind designed to fit on the inner frame of mountain bikes. For a terrifying second, Hershel was sure that his father was going to demand a twenty-mile bike ride or some other terror, but instead the enormous man just handed him the bottle.

"I think that's as much as we have time for today."

"Oh," Hershel said. "So I should leave now, I guess."

Owen shook his head. "I promised Roy proof by tonight. Now it's time for me to pony up."

Hershel pulled out the stopper top on the plastic bottle and sniffed. Definitely whiskey.

"You haven't even trained him yet. All we did today was work on me."

"Trust me." Owen gave his son a reassuring smile, one that made Hershel feel good, then feel guilty for feeling good. He might have been more inclined to argue, but he was sore, tired, and curious. The whiskey would cure the first two; hopefully some answers would satisfy the last one. A long drink drained the bottle of its contents and initiated Hershel's transformation.

By the time Roy stood up, the fatigue in their muscles had completely dissipated. If anything, he felt more energetic than usual. Rather than jumping about, Roy simply looked at his father and narrowed his eyes.

"Well?"



“Weights,” Owen snapped back at him. The giant of a man lumbered across the yard, stopping at a set of weights he’d used to put Hershel through the paces only a few hours previously. This time Owen didn’t reach for any of the shiny silver ones; instead his massive hands wrapped around a pair of dumbbells that were charcoal black. Roy recognized them as the hyper-dense weights used to train people with super strength. These weren’t quite as well maintained as the ones at Lander, but the dents they left in the ground as Owen pulled them up left no doubt that their heft was still impressive.

Roy came up to the larger man and held out his hands. Owen deposited a dumbbell in each, placing them down as easily as if they were merely awkwardly-shaped pillows. To Roy they weren’t nearly so easy to deal with; his arms were straining with just the effort of holding them up. He wondered if Hershel’s workout had left him weaker than he realized.

“Let’s warm up,” Owen said. “Those are seven hundred and fifty pounds each. Even you should be able to handle them for six reps.”

There was a snapping click as Roy’s jaw set at the words ‘even you’ and a small vein in the young man’s forehead bulged with an effort that had nothing to do with the weights in his hands. It was successful; somehow he managed to hold his tongue and focus on the task at hand. Roy moved the dumbbells up and down slowly, ensuring that the tension on his biceps never slacked. It took more work than he remembered seven hundred and fifty pounds requiring, but he did the six and then did three more on top of that. Whether those last three were out of pride, spite, or some mixture of the two could be debated, but they got done with perfect form nonetheless. Roy carefully set the weights on the ground, all-too aware of the damage that material could do if dropped aimlessly.

“Not bad,” Owen complimented, settled down in sitting position on the weight bench. “So, you remember what I told Hershel earlier, right?”

“I’m guessing you mean that bullshit about us not being shifters.”

“That’s the part. Play devil’s advocate with me for a minute. If you weren’t shifters, what other explanation could there be for your power?” Owen asked calmly.

“I don’t know. Is being fucking awesome enough to make you a Super now?”

“You are pretty awesome,” Owen agreed. “Confident, good-looking, athletic, strong, tough, even charming when you’re motivated. All the things a

male wants to be at some point in his life. You got them all. Have you ever wondered why that is?”

“What the hell are you talking about? I’m just me, why would I wonder about that?”

“If you were just a shifted form of Hershel, then why would your identities separate? Why would your personalities diverge so greatly? Heck, if you were just a version of your brother with powers then why wouldn’t you look the same? Not all strongmen have muscular frames after all.”

“I... I don’t really know,” Roy admitted. He resisted the urge to shuffle uncomfortably. That was shit Hershel would do. Instead Roy just kept his gaze locked on his father’s eyes.

“Maybe because you’re not just a stronger version of Hershel. You’re literally everything Hershel has wanted to be, but wasn’t. Do you remember when you first appeared?”

“We were kids. Some classmates were making fun of Hershel. They were calling him fat and slow and ugly. He got really upset and a minute later there I was.”

“A boy who wasn’t fat, slow, or ugly. A boy who couldn’t get beat up, whose ego was strong enough to withstand their taunts.”

Roy realized he was flexing his hands into fists involuntarily. Something about this conversation was making him very uncomfortable. “Can we cut to the fucking point, old man?”

“You two aren’t shifters,” Owen reinstated. “You inherited my power, but you got a better version of it. I adapt to new challenges or injuries, my body improves itself to overcome them. There’s a threshold to how high I can take that. Sooner or later I run out of things I can train myself to be immune to, eventually I can’t find heavy enough things to improve my strength on. There’s a logistical cap to my power, one that doesn’t apply to you.”

“What the- what are trying to say we are?”

“You have the power of adaption. Hershel is the human side, the one who can always find more challenges. When he encounters a need to be stronger or tougher, your maximum potential increases in proportion. The reason you’ve been stuck in place is because Hershel didn’t need to be stronger; you’ve been fighting his battles and doing all the physical work for

most of your adult life.”

“That doesn’t make sense. I only hit a wall this year!” Roy seemed unaware of the increasing volume of his voice.

“That’s because you didn’t try until you entered the HCP. You had catching up to do. When Hershel trains, it raises your potential. When you train, it increases your actual strength. You are Hershel’s reaction to the challenges of life; you get whatever he needs in a moment of failure or stress. Physical, psychological, doesn’t matter. It’s why you two are so different and why you have separate minds.”

“I’m not some nerd’s fucking fantasy ego! I’m my own person, and if you’d actually stayed around instead of running off maybe you would fucking know that!” Roy turned and stormed off toward the bar. “You’re full of shit and I’ve wasted enough time here. I’m going to the beach with our friends.”

How a man his size moved so fast, Roy would never know, but Owen closed the gap between them and placed a massive hand on his son’s shoulder. The grip wasn’t too tight, but it was firm enough to send the message that this conversation wasn’t over.

“You think I’m full of shit? Then tell me something, how did you lift nine hundred pounds with each hand a few minutes ago?”

“It was seven hundred and fifty.”

“I lied. It was nine hundred.”

Roy slowly turned to face his father. Owen flashed his son a devilish grin, one that Roy wouldn’t realize until much later he’d seen on his own face in the mirror more times than he could count. It was a smile that said quite clearly the wearer had gotten exactly the outcome they wanted.

“Who’s full of shit now?”

## 137.

By the third day, several of the beach-dwelling students had grown weary of the amateur cooking that half-drunk college sophomores could produce, so a small excursion was mounted to a local bar and grill. Nick, Alice, Thomas, and Will managed to snare a table amidst the thick crowd of fellow college students, whether it was due to genuine luck or a bit of Nick's interference was anyone's guess. Regardless, the four huddled around the polished wooden tabletop and scrolled through menus coated in a sticky substance they all hoped was spilled liquor.

"Classy joint," Nick commented, raising his voice slightly to be heard over the dull roar of intoxicated college students. He wondered if he'd put in too much effort on the fake IDs; some of the ones he'd seen walking in the door had been little better than cardboard with photos glued to them, yet they had all garnered entrance. Hell, the bouncer hadn't even looked at Alice's, but that probably had more to do with the tight tank-top half shirt and beach shorts she was dressed in.

"I offered to get us into a nice steakhouse," Alice reminded him.

"You've already done more than enough," Thomas said. "Besides, this is part of the spring break experience."

"If only there were some other place we could have hung around a giant crowd of drunks. Perhaps some sort of well-stocked beach house," Will conjectured.

"Oh, stop being a spoil-sport. It's good to get out on occasion," Alice said. "Tell you what, you guys find some appetizers we can share, I'll go get us drinks. Beers all around?"

"Water for me," Will corrected.

"Right. Beers all around." Alice flashed her friend a daring smile, then began squeezing her way through the crowd toward the packed bar.

"I suppose I'll be drinking after all."

"Don't mind her, she just wants everyone to have fun," Nick said. "The girl thinks we're all wound too tight and this is her chance to help us blow off some steam."

“She isn’t entirely off the mark on that one,” Thomas concurred. “I don’t think I’ve seen everyone let their hair down this much since the river trip. Even then it might not have been as much, because we had to keep setting up camp and keeping together. This is just a week of pure fun and relaxation.”

“And who better to champion that spirit than our bubbly, glitter-eyed blonde,” Nick said.

“I can’t think of a soul. Well, maybe Violet,” Thomas conceded. “That girl does love her beer.”

“So much so that she is trying to train us all to down a hundred shots of it in the span of a hundred minutes,” Will pointed out. “Which, by the way, very well might give someone alcohol poisoning.”

“Good thing Camille will be there,” Thomas said with a shrug. He was more than accustomed to Violet’s antics by this point; the best strategy was to prep for damage control and hope things didn’t get too out of hand.

Nick started to respond, but he noticed Alice making her way back to the table. She was balancing two beers in each hand and walking carefully. Something was wrong; her eyes were downcast and her form seemed to be pulling in on itself. Alice usually walked with assertive confidence: a stunning figure and years of cultured upbringing will do that to a person. Right now, in contrast, she seemed embarrassed. It only took Nick a quick sweep of the room and a sorting of voices to discern the reason why.

Alice was being catcalled by some drunk guys at the bar.

“Hey, come on baby, don’t be like that. Come back and have a drink with us.”

“Fuck, you’ve got an ass, girl. I want to bounce my dick off of it.”

“I love the glitter! Are you a stripper, ’cause if so I’d like to buy a dance.”

Alice had reached the table by the last one and Nick felt something in his gut tighten. Her eyes, beneath the smear of pink sparkles she’d taken to applying on a regular basis, were beginning to grow moist. She set the beers down silently and angled herself away from the rest of the table.

Thomas and Will hadn’t noticed the boisterous voices; they were easy to miss amidst the chaos if you weren’t listening for them, so they didn’t

know why Alice had returned in a significantly sadder mood. It was only a matter of time until they pieced things together; both of them were perceptive enough to figure it out. That situation was too dangerous to be allowed to manifest.

“Guys, why don’t you go find a waitress and get us some wings,” Nick said. “Right now, if you don’t mind.”

Thomas and Will looked at each other. Something was off with Nick. His affable, silly demeanor had all but evaporated. When he spoke that request, if it could be called one, it was with absolute authority, as if even the idea of being disobeyed was a foreign concept to him. It was strange, but Nick was right: they were both perceptive. It was obvious something was going on, and they would give their friend the space he needed. For now.

“Sure,” Thomas said. “We’ll be close by, just in case you decide you want anything else.”

“Much appreciated,” Nick said without looking at them. Thomas and Will peeled off and began wading away from their table, toward a small serving area near the back of the restaurant. Once they were gone, Nick leaned in toward Alice so he could lower his voice. “Alice, there’s something I’ve been wondering about.”

“What?” She still faced away from him, but he could tell her voice was thicker than normal. She was still fighting back tears.

“The glitter you wear: it’s because of your mother, isn’t it?”

Alice whipped her head around and stared at him with a surprised look.

“High attention to detail, and I got you that book of pictures of her for your last birthday, remember? You’ve never shown any interest in that kind of look - in fact, you usually stay away from it - and then after you get some as a gift it starts showing up on you all the time. Didn’t take a genius to figure out.”

Alice nodded slowly. “My dad told me she used to wear it all the time. Said she believed it was impossible to be unhappy when you were sparkly.”

“I see.” Nick took off his sunglasses and pulled his cell phone out of his pocket. He slid both across the table toward Alice. “When this is over, call speed dial number three on my phone. Tell the person on the other

end my name, where we are, and let him know I need a Counter's Exit."

"What does that... what are you going to do?"

## 138.

Nick didn't answer Alice's question; instead he dropped off his stool and moved toward the bar. While the others had jostled and pushed their way through the crowd, Nick flowed through it like a river across a bed of rocks. He barely got touched by the time he reached the three drunken offenders.

"Good evening, gentlemen."

The tallest one, a frosted-tip blonde who had made the stripper comment, looked him up and down. "What do you want?"

"I want you to apologize to my friend, beg her for forgiveness, and then get the hell out of this place while it's still an option." There was no aggression in Nick's voice or his body language; if anything, he seemed to be perfectly peaceful. The only hint of what was simmering beneath his calm surface was his choice of words.

"Go fuck yourself." This one was smaller than Tips, a dense figure with a close shave along the top of his head and a tribal tattoo encircling a sizable bicep.

"Yeah, get out of here before we get annoyed." The third fellow was darker skinned than the other, lean with long hair.

"So, just to be clear, you are refusing to act like men and own up to your drunken acts of rudeness? Rather you prefer to be petulant children, content to wallow in their own idiocy while giving each other congratulatory hand jobs over their perceived prowess with women?"

"What the hell did you just say?" Tattoo asked. Nick sighed; it seemed despite their status as seekers of higher education he was going to have to go low-brow in order to move this along. He really had hoped for a quick resolution, but the longer he delayed the greater the risk that Thomas or Will would get involved. Well, when in doubt, play the odds. Since he was dealing with drunken adolescents trying to prove their masculinity, it didn't take a big leap of intelligence to guess what might set them off.

"I called you cowardly morons and implied that you were gay. You know, pillow-biters, pole-smokers, fudge-"

Nick was interrupted as Tattoo stumbled off his chair and took a swing at him. "Finally," Nick mumbled under his breath. He sidestepped the



drunken punch and drove his own fist into the muscular man's throat. Tattoo immediately began to cough and clutch where Nick had struck, which left him defenseless for the follow up blow to his right ear. Long Hair finally began reacting, lurching forward to help his friend. Nick delivered a sharp kick to his sternum, slamming him back-first into the edge of the bar. Nick made no attempt to conceal the boredom evident on his face.

Tips finally jumped into the fray, clearly surprised at his lackeys' inability to handle one lone challenge. He reared back and swung with all of his might. Nick was disappointed; even if they weren't intoxicated, these three were still too slow to be any kind of a challenge. As drunks, well, they were hardly worth all the training his Vegas teachers had given him in the art of quick combat. This was not a style most of his HCP peers would have been familiar with. The vast majority of their martial arts were rooted in the idea of defense, in minimizing harm to each party and subduing a threat. Nicholas hadn't been taught that kind of fighting. He'd never learned how to win fights; he'd been too busy being taught how to end them.

Nick plucked an empty beer bottle off a nearby table and used it to meet Tips' punch. He couldn't hear the subtle cracking of the small bones in his hand, but the way the taller boy howled in pain still confirmed that Nick had been successful. He used the time to deliver a few quick kidney blows and send Long Hair stumbling to the floor.

This had all happened in less than ten seconds, so quickly that neither the other patrons nor the bouncers had time to react. That was changing; Nick could see two massive forms slowly shoving their way through the crowd. His way of fighting was quick and efficient, built for injury and swift victory. Still, he needed to step it up if he wanted to finish in time.

Tips was still clutching his hand as Nick's fingers snarled through his hair and jerked him to a near standing position.

"Believe it or not, today I've been your damn savior," Nick hissed in the now-terrified drunk's ear. "We live in a world where gods masquerade in mortal flesh. Learn some fucking propriety." Nick jerked the jerk's head back then drove it forward on a collision course with the edge of the bar. He was well-versed in the use of hard surfaces in a fight; it was one of the first things you learned handling drunks in Vegas. If he angled it right, Nick could give this asshole permanent brain damage. In another direction it could do long-term damage to his eye. Briefly Nick entertained both of those options; however, in the end he remembered that Alice was watching, so it was

probably best to show at least some mercy.

“Mah teef!” Tips slurred from his bloody mouth. Funny thing about people: they always clenched their jaws when anticipating a hit. If you drove that tight mouth into a hard corner, you could do quite a bit of damage along both rows of teeth. It would only be cosmetic and could easily be capped, but it would hurt like a mother fucker.

“You’re welcome,” Nick said, staring down at the victims of his carnage with a curved smile slicing across his face. As the bouncers closed around him, the smile never wavered nor faded: if anything it seemed to grow more intense. It would be years before Tips would stop seeing that smile in his nightmares, a predicament many regretful former drunken gamblers in Las Vegas could have sympathized with.

Five tables away, Alice’s mouth hung open as they dragged Nick out the door. As quietly as she could, Alice scooped up his phone and sunglasses and followed them at a distance.

By the time Thomas and Will had gotten the wings ordered, it was all over and both of their classmates were already gone.

“Campbell, Nicholas. You’re up.”

Nick happily stood from the stiff wooden bench he’d been sitting on. The cell wasn’t too bad; he’d certainly been tossed in worse over the years. Plus, it was still early in the evening, so there was only one drunk accompanying him. That dapper gentleman had passed out on the opposite side of the bench before soiling himself, so Nick was quite glad the family extractor had been quick with this one.

“Never seen someone get cleared of assault so fast,” the police officer remarked as his keys jingled in the lock. “You must have a hell of a lawyer.”

Nick gave him a sheepish smile, nothing like the devil’s grin he’d worn when being dragged away from his victims. “Something like that.” The jailer didn’t need to know that the order had actually come from a local politician who either owed the family a favor or owed someone who owed them. Crime only didn’t pay if you forgot to give the politicians their piece of the pie.

“Can’t believe a little guy like you took down three fellows. I mean, you’re fit, but the report said any one of them had twenty pounds and a few inches on you.” The jailer’s face grew uncertain as he pulled open the door. “You... you ain’t one of those Supers, are you?”

“Man, don’t I wish. Nah, the simple truth of it is that big guys can’t fight worth a crap. They’re big, so no one ever challenges them. We smaller folks know how to scrap because we’re the ones everyone tries to take on.”

The jailer’s face eased; this explanation clearly fit into his worldview. “Well, you’re free to go. Seems everyone saw them throw the first punches and you didn’t have any booze in you, so this is officially self-defense.” He closed the door and re-locked it, lest the pee-soaked drunk get any ideas of escape. “By the way, there’s a girl waiting for you in the lobby. She what this whole thing was about?”

“It’s possible,” Nick admitted.

“Can’t say I blame you then,” the jailer said with a conspiratorial wink. “Can’t say I blame you one bit.”

\* \* \*

Hershel's body was aching as he lay on the hotel's plush bed. He could have shifted to Roy, but Owen had been adamant that the more he was able to push himself, the better the results would be. Evidently working through pain was a part of that equation. It was invaluable experience; the closer Hershel could come to complete bodily destruction, the greater the gain for Roy would be. He would have to pick up an exercise regimen once back at Lander, but this kind of intense training was far too dangerous to do without experienced supervision.

Hershel found he couldn't just sit still, in spite of his body's fervent demands he do just that. He decided to compromise and engage his mind. A sore walk over to the desk and few quick button punches fired up his laptop and jumped his connection onto the free hotel WiFi. The hotel's front page came up, along with a few advertisements for local businesses a weary traveler might be interested in. There, in the lower left hand of the screen, was a small ad for Owen's bar: Tartarus.

Hershel suppressed a grim chuckle. His father never had been all that creative. Owen had only taken the name Titan at a friend's suggestion when he couldn't think of anything better. Naming his bar after the place where the gods had sealed away the titans of ancient myth... it was just so predictable. Not that it was really appropriate, anyway. The Titan Scandal had certainly changed things for him; however, it didn't have to mean his exile. Owen made that choice himself.

A new browser window opened and a quick search revealed countless articles about the former Hero. Amidst the hate-speech and conspiracy theories, there were a few archives of images taken of him before the scandal. There he was knocking out a gorilla equipped in a battle suit. There was one of him lifting a bus of children off of a collapsing bridge. There he was shaking the president's hand. It always looked so effortless, in his blue jeans, red mask, and red shirt. No wonder he was considered one of America's great Heroes. A strong, powerful man, who often talked about his wonderful family, though never with enough detail to deduce his identity. A steady anchor of decency for people of all walks to rally around. A symbol of goodness and morality. Everyone loved Titan.

Until he was caught having sex with another man.

Honestly, Hershel was amazed his mother had kept the truth of what happened from him for so long. He'd been in his teens before he finally found out about the Titan Scandal, a few weeks after Roy's fateful trip out here.

He'd found out about the reporter who'd spied on Titan, hoping to glean some information on his identity, and instead recorded the famous family man carnally engaged in homosexual acts. The cheating was bad, but one would think that in this day and age people wouldn't have completely lost their shit over something like that. One would think wrong.

Hershel browsed through the articles now, it wasn't like he was going to read anything new. Conservative groups denounced Titan as a sinner and a liar who was secretly promoting his gay agenda. Homosexual advocacy groups rallied around his image in support. Conspiracy theorists screamed to anyone who would listen that the whole thing had been set up by a shadow government. And, in the eye of the media storm, hidden away in a small house in Chicago, a family self-destructed as a piece of truth that Owen had been trying to hide from everyone, even himself, finally came to light.

No one banished Titan. There was no law that a homosexual, or any minority for that matter, couldn't be a Hero. He was the one who walked away. He was the one who couldn't handle being a Hero once his precious image was shattered. He was the one who left his family to come run a gay bar in Colorado. The man who had taught Hershel and Roy about honesty, integrity, and living up to one's obligations had walked away from everyone who depended on him.

That was the only part Hershel and Roy couldn't forgive.

Hershel clicked off the computer and walked back to the bed. Suddenly sleep sounded far more intriguing than it had half an hour ago.

Nick and Alice plodded along the shoreline, well-illuminated by the lights from the nearby street and the glowing moon overhead. Neither had said much since leaving the station; Alice had grabbed a cab to follow Nick since Thomas had driven them to the bar, but being unable to find one nearby after Nick's release had left them with only the option of walking a few miles to the house or calling a friend to pick them up. Explaining why they were at a police station seemed like more effort than a sand-covered trek, so off they'd gone.

"You really beat the hell out of those guys," Alice said after about ten minutes of walking in silence. "I mean... you went after them." Her voice was weaker than usual; her worry seemed to physically weigh down her words.

"They attacked me first," Nick replied, pausing to knock some of the sand from his flip-flops.

"Bullshit. I know you well enough to know they did exactly what you wanted them to do. They were drunk idiots and I'm not really sorry they got hurt but... I've never seen that look in your eyes before." Despite the warm spring air, Alice shivered slightly. "Nick, you looked savage, scary, and happier than I think I've ever seen before. Is that... was that... the real you?"

Nick finished knocking away the sand and looked up at her. She was staring at him, resisting the urge to look away even though it was clear she wanted to. Her right arm was pulled across her stomach, something of a half-hug for reassurance. In this light she looked smaller than normal, yet somehow more beautiful as the soft light illuminated her features.

"Are you cashing in your marker?"

"What?"

"Our bet, from the second team event. I promised you an honest answer to one question if you won your match. I'm asking if you want to use it for this question, right now."

Alice was silent for a moment then shook her head.

"Then I'm going to say no, and you'll have to decide for yourself whether it's the truth or not." Nick turned to resume their journey, but Alice wasn't done with the discussion yet.

“You didn’t have to do it that way. I was okay, it was just words. You didn’t have to hurt them.”

“Words are more powerful than people think,” Nick said with a sigh. “As for not hurting them, I’ll admit I’m pretty new to the world of friendship - hell, I’m still grappling with the idea of even having real friends - but one thing I’m sure of is that I’m not going to stand around and do nothing while someone hurts a person I care about. Besides, it was the best outcome.”

“How was that the best outcome?”

“Thomas and Will were there too. Thomas is like Vince, overprotective to a fault. He would have knocked those guys senseless once he figured it out. As for Will, let’s just say I’ve seen the look in his eyes when he gets serious, and he’s not someone I would purposely make an enemy of. Both would have taken action; neither of them have my connections. Jail would have been a much bigger deal, especially if it came out that they were Supers.”

“I... I can’t believe I missed this. I get it now.”

“Yup; just trying to keep things moving along nicely.”

“No. You were protecting all of us,” Alice said, some of her usual authority returning to her tone.

“Whoa now, let’s not go overboard. I just didn’t want the week to get spoiled. We’re all having too much fun. One of us getting locked up would have brought everyone down.”

“It would have. And an arrest for fighting humans would have been a serious black mark against Thomas or Will when they tried to advance to the next year,” Alice surmised. “You weren’t just hitting them on my behalf, you were doing it before the others had a chance because you knew you could walk away.”

Nick sighed and looked out at the ocean lapping onto the shore. This was why he loathed people with unpredictable perception. He could usually slip so much by Alice, but every now and then she caught something he didn’t expect her to see. It was quite annoying.

“Look, I think you’re giving me too much-”

“Why are you in the HCP?” Alice interrupted. Her passive posture was gone; now she moved slightly toward him, shoulders set and eyes full of

steel. “And yes, I’m calling in my marker or whatever you said. Honest, complete answer. I want to know.”

“Have to admit, I wasn’t expecting that one. Mind if I ask why?”

“I just want to understand,” Alice replied. “What I saw today, that beast in your eyes as you smacked those guys around, it was kind of terrifying. But then, when I really think back, it seems like you’re always doing stuff like that. Playing the idiot or the ass and making missteps so the rest of us won’t. You go so far out of your way to act like a dick, but if someone were to look carefully, they’d see you’re always protecting the rest of us. I’m trying to figure out what’s real and what isn’t. The HCP wasn’t a mandatory part of the program, it was an offer. I’m hoping that knowing why you took that offer might help me figure things out.”

“I suppose I can see the thought process there,” Nick admitted. He walked toward the water and Alice followed a few steps behind. At the edge of the tide line he kicked off his flip-flops and trod a few feet further. The water pushed itself up the shore, covering his feet then pulling away, sinking him slightly as it stole away the sand.

“The reason I told the... my family is that this is training I can’t get anywhere else in the world. There are big plans for me, and bringing my ability under control would go a long way toward reaching those goals. In my entrance interview I told the school I wanted in because it was a chance to finally get control of something that had run my life for so long, to turn a handicap into an asset. Both are true, although the reasoning behind the second is different than a person who didn’t know me might assume. But if I’m being completely honest, there is a third piece of the puzzle as to why I enrolled in the HCP.”

Alice pulled her own shoes off and joined him in the water’s path. She stood close, close enough that he could feel her presence tingling along his arm, but without touching him. The waves rolled in and rolled out. Their gentle lapping was the only sound either could hear. Alice waited.

“I was a kid once. I mean, not a very normal one, and I don’t remember having a child’s mentality for long, but I was a kid once. Gerry used to tell me stories and read books to me. He loved classics. Don Quixote, Sir Gawain and the Green Knight, shit like that. I read comic books too, once I could read on my own. I played pretend that I was a noble knight rescuing princesses. I put a towel on like a cape and ran around making flying noises.” Nick paused as he ran his hand through his sandy hair.



“Even someone like me wanted to be the hero, once upon a time. Dreamed about making the world a better place. Believed that one person could make a difference. All that crap. I came to Lander mostly for the logical reasons I gave everyone else. However, complete honesty, I think some part of me wanted to touch that fantasy again. Maybe a chunk of me even wanted to believe in real heroes, not just Supers with the title. Silly, especially saying it out loud, but it’s the truth and that’s what you wanted.”

“You were a kid once,” Alice repeated. Her hand worked its way carefully into his, intertwining her digits amidst those dexterous fingers as a fresh wave washed over their feet.

“Yeah. Did that help with your dilemma?”

Alice smiled and turned to face him. “Not really.”

“Oh well. Can’t win ‘em all.”

Camille lay out on the deck, staring up at the stars and listening to the waves roll across the sand. The week had flown by, her memories of it a mental collage of swimming, games, and healing lots of people's hangovers. It had been a good time with her friends, despite the fact that she'd spent less time with Vince than she might have otherwise preferred. He'd seemed distracted since the second day, spending more time than usual off on his own. The boy probably went on three solo runs a day. Still, that was just one fly in the ointment of a wonderful week, so she couldn't complain that much.

There was a soft thud as the door behind her opened. People had been wandering out occasionally, letting the night air bring some clarity to their thoughts before heading back into the den of chaos. So far the night was on the tame side, but Violet had declared tonight reserved for her Centennial Club, so it wasn't surprising that people were hesitant to pre-drink before such a booze-heavy endeavor.

"Hey." Vince's voice came slightly ahead of him, his familiar form drifting into Camille's field of vision a few seconds after the word hit her ears.

"Hey yourself," she replied. She noticed he was holding one of the many plastic cups that had been used to house beer, cocktails, and - on very rare occasions - water. "Careful; you let Violet see you walking around with a plastic cup, she'll assume you've decided to drink. That makes you fair game for tonight's challenge."

Vince took a sip from the aforementioned cup and winced visibly. "Nick made me a screwdriver. Apparently the orange juice is supposed to mask the taste of the alcohol."

"Oh. Does it?"

"Not with the amount Nick poured." Vince motioned to the empty deck chair next to her. "Mind if I join you?"

"By all means." Camille waited until he'd settled into a reclining position before asking her next question. "So, what's weighing on your mind?"

"Am I that easy to read?"

“You’ve been a little distracted all week, which admittedly could have been you keeping away from the wild party crowd, but now you’re drinking alcohol. Last time you did that was when you were worried about losing your spot in the HCP over grades. So in summary: yes, you are very much that easy to read.”

“When you put it like that...” Vince trailed off and took another swig of his screwdriver. He shook his head after the gulp. “Sweet heaven this is awful. Want to try it?” He extended the cup to his deckchair neighbor.

“Why would I want to try something awful?”

“No idea. Seemed polite to at least offer.”

Camille accepted the plastic container but made no motion to sip from it. Instead she moved it from hand to hand as she looked out at the starlight-speckled dark sky.

“Sasha wants to get back together with me.”

“Oh.” Camille took a short sip from the cup in her hands. Vince had not exaggerated the awfulness of the vodka concoction. She put the drink back to her lips and took a much longer draw. “I’m guessing that’s confusing for you?”

“Very. I mean, I was in love with her last year when things fell apart, but once I saw how she felt about me, I really did my best to move on. I suppose deep down a part of me always hoped that she’d change her mind, but that part of me didn’t actually bother to figure out what I wanted beyond that.”

“So now that you can have her, you’re not sure if you want her?” Camille took one last guzzle and handed the now noticeably lighter cup back to Vince. With her small frame she knew she’d already downed more than was prudent, but if this conversation went the way she was anticipating, a little numbness might be worth the other effects of intoxication.

Vince laughed lightly and accepted his cup. “No, I think it would be accurate to say now that having her is a reality, not just a lonely fantasy, I have to face the real consequences of what making that choice would be.”

“Consequences like having back the girl you wanted.”

“See, that’s just it. The girl I wanted. The girl I loved. I still feel things for her, I won’t deny that, but after everything that’s happened, I’m not sure

that I still want to be in a relationship with her. It's hard to tell if I want to be with her, or I just want to be with someone."

"That doesn't sound like you at all."

"Everyone gets lonely, Camille. I don't think there's any shame in admitting that sometimes the desire to just have someone to be with is there, even if you don't have a particular someone in mind."

"No, I suppose you're right. It's human nature, and even we not-quite-human freaks aren't immune."

"Freaks," Vince said, tasting the word before washing it away with the remainder of his drink. "I hate that word."

Camille realized her faux pas immediately. "Vince, I'm sorry. That was just a bad choice of words, I didn't mean anything by it."

He looked over at her and gave his reassuring smile. "I know you didn't. You've never once treated any of us like we were different just because we used to be Powered. I bet you would have been nice to us even if we weren't Supers." Vince turned back to the sky and put his hands behind his head. "No, I hate that word for different reasons. When I was traveling around I heard people talking about Supers a lot, and that was the most common word they used. Freaks. They said it with so much anger and contempt, this whole unacknowledged sentiment of hate directed toward people just for the way they were born. People think being a Powered is hard, and it is, but the world usually looked at us with annoyance or pity. People who could control their abilities, they were the ones who were despised."

Camille nodded, not trusting herself to talk. Too many memories of her life before meeting Vince were trying to bubble up in her mind, aided a bit by the generous dose of vodka now working through her system. Camille understood how people hated Supers. She understood very well.

"Sorry, I guess I went off on a ramble there," Vince said. "Anyway, I've spent the week trying to figure out what to do about Sasha, and all I've managed is to make myself more confused, so tonight I'm going the opposite direction and trying not to think. Hence my letting Nick make me a drink. I'll try not to burden you with loss of stomach control this time, at least."

He gave her a playful wink, and just like that the serious cloud that had settled over them was dispelled. Camille's bad memories faded back into the recesses of her subconscious, replaced by the shining one of when she'd

first looked up at the stalwart man now sitting across from her.

“If you do then you’re in deep trouble, because I doubt I’ll be in any shape to help.”

“Screwdriver already hitting you that hard?”

“No, but the many shots of beer I’m about to take will probably push me way over the edge. Let’s go tell Violet we’re playing along.”

“Is that a good idea? Neither of us is a really heavy drinker.”

“No, it’s a terrible idea, but I think we’re both responsible enough to be allowed one of those on occasion. Besides, we won’t try to do the whole thing, just what we can manage.” The small girl pulled herself up the chair and looked down at Vince, tapping her foot against the wooden floor of the deck.

“Yup, this is a horrible idea,” Vince said, grinning as he rose up and followed her back into the ruckus of the house.

## 142.

Owen's punch sent Roy three feet in the air and twenty feet back. The younger man crashed to the ground in a rolling heap, his movement continuing until he wound up back on his feet. If not for his own levels of endurance to physical damage, that blow would likely have broken his sternum. Instead it just felt like it had.

"You managed to deflect most of the power from that one," Owen complimented. "Most people with our ability fight like they don't understand the concept of injury. It's nice to see that school of yours has at least been teaching you the basics of intelligent fighting."

Roy patted himself down while his father talked, double checking for any serious wounds. Even with a step back and a strike against Owen's forearm, that punch still had enough force to warrant concern. If Roy had taken it full force, well, he was reasonably sure it wouldn't have killed him, but that probably would have been the end of their last day's training. Hershel was slated to drive back to Lander tomorrow morning, so this was the final iteration of Owen's Intense Battle Camp. It hadn't been an easy week, but the results were already showing themselves.

"They teach us a lot," Roy said after he was sure his bones were still in the correct number of pieces. "Plus I had a hell of a sparring partner last year. He showed me the value in not getting hit."

"Not getting hit is a damned fine skill to master," Owen said with a nod. "But, for us, it comes second to being able to take one."

"Isn't that the exact opposite of learning not to get hit?"

"No; knowing how to avoid attacks is fine, when you have that option. Let me ask you something about this sparring partner of yours: what is his power?"

"Complete control of his body, down to a molecular level."

"Damn, that's a pretty fine one. So I'm guessing he can do some interesting things with it."

"He can speed up his perception of time, perfect memory, and I once saw him heal a cut on his head in a couple of seconds. All of that on top of the fact that he's strong as shit." Roy might have spoken higher of Chad's

impressive punching power if not for the offhanded blow his father had dealt him. The man was redefining Roy's very concept of strength.

"Ten to twenty he also has a bunch of tricks you haven't even seen yet," Owen commented. "Things he can do that will help in a variety of situations. Probably even ways to subdue other Supers without injuring them. That's why he knows how to avoid being hit; for him that will always be priority one. You and I don't have variety. We do two things well. Hit, and get hit. That's our bread and butter. That's where we live."

"I don't get it, why the hell can't I counter or dodge?"

"You can, when it's appropriate. But what are you going to do when your team is staring down a fully-charged energy beam that fires directly at your group? You going to dodge? Because you might get away, or at least get by uninjured. Not all of your teammates will be able to do the same."

"What would you do in that situation?"

"Same thing I've always done in that situation. I'd charge the fucking thing and take the full brunt of it. Because that's my job, just like the healer would fix whatever it broke on me and the ranged guys would tear it up before it could fire again."

"What if it destroyed you?"

"That's why we train like this. Not just to push our limits, but to be aware of them. A strongman who doesn't know how much he can take won't last very long, not unless his endurance is so top-class it might as well be invulnerability. Every Super who makes it to Hero is intimately familiar with what they can and can't do. It's why different teams get different assignments. It's why strategies are altered depending on the threat. Your sparring partner will have a myriad of options for how he handles his shit. You have two."

"Hit and get hit," Roy echoed, nodding his head with understanding at last.

"Exactly; so you better train like hell to make sure you can do both better than everyone else you know."

"I'll keep that in mind," Roy said. He glanced at the sun's position in the sky. He could probably push it a while longer, but the day was definitely beginning to lose ground in the fight against evening. From the discussion they'd just had, Owen would likely come at him hard: hard enough to put him

down for a while. That might mean being here during business hours, which was not a particularly desirable outcome.

“Well, thanks for the training.” Roy’s posture changed as he purposely took himself out of a ready stance. “Day is almost over, so I’m going to call it. Have a good one.” He turned and headed toward the exit, not really expecting to get out this easy, but still hoping for it.

“Wait, you’re leaving?” Roy couldn’t see Owen’s face, but the poorly-suppressed sadness in his voice made it far too easy to picture.

“Of course. Have to get up early to drive back, and we’re getting close to business hours. I believe it was one of your rules that I be gone by the time the doors open, right?”

“Yeah, I suppose it was.” Owen’s voice broke off near the end; for once the unstoppable man was unsure about how to go forward. “Look, I know you’ve got a life to get home to, one that hasn’t involved me for a long time, but I was thinking that we could try to stay in touch-”

“Pass,” Roy said, giving in at last and turning around. Owen’s face was more controlled than he’d expected, but his eyes told the story of a man barely holding it together. “Don’t get me wrong, Hershel and I both appreciate what you’ve done for us here. It’s not an exaggeration to say that if I make it as a Hero, it will be at least partly due to you. You taught me the truth about what I am.”

Roy walked back toward his father until he was only a few steps away. It was probably less than five feet of separation, but miles stretched in between each one of those feet.

“I’m truly grateful. So grateful I’ve kept civil this whole week. That’s it. That’s the end of it.”

“I understand,” Owen said with a heavy sigh. “I didn’t really expect you to understand any of this.” He gestured a massive hand back at Tartarus to illustrate the point.

“You think I don’t want to get reacquainted with you because of the gay thing?”

“Don’t you?”

“Fuck you,” Roy spat. “Mom raised me better than that. Look, let me ask you a question. You know the Hero, Globe?”



Owen nodded. "I met him once or twice. We never worked on the same team or anything."

"One of the other people in my program, Vince, was raised by a guy who some people are speculating might be him. They think Globe faked his death, lived as a hobo wanderer, took in some street urchin Powered, and took care of him until his early teens. Honestly, I think it's bullshit, but even if Vince really was raised by a psychopath murderer in hiding, I'm still jealous of him. Want to guess why?"

"I-"

"Because his father was fucking there. He taught him how to fight, how to survive, how to be a man. You should see the way Vince lights up when he talks about him. Might secretly be one of the greatest villains of our age, had no blood relation to the kid, and he was still a better dad than you. Even if he'd done a shitty job, at least he was punching the clock. You just fucking quit. That's why I don't want you in my life. You already made the choice to cut me out of yours."

"Roy, you don't understand how difficult things were. Even if the world didn't know I was Titan, our community did. We hung out with other Heroes, every person in my world was suddenly looking at me like... I don't even have words. And that's to say nothing of the pain I saw in your mother's eyes. I'm not proud of the choice I made but I thought it was best for the family to take me out of it."

"Bullshit. It was just easier. You had a kid who would uncontrollably turn into someone else with strength, endurance, and shitty impulse control, and somehow you looked at that situation and decided he'd be better without anyone to teach him what it meant to be different. Better yet, to take away the person he looked up to and had wanted to be like. I'm not saying staying wouldn't have been hard, but don't you dare look me in the eye and tell me that you ran away for the family."

Owen's eyes tightened as he looked back at his son. "I guess this is it then."

"I guess so," Roy agreed. "Thanks for the training, and for the mantra. Hit and get hit. Protect the people around you. I think that's a solid philosophy for people like us." Roy turned and walked to the door, this time unhalting by any outcry from Owen.

"Hit and get hit," Owen said softly as he watched his son walk out of

his life.

## 143.

By the time Vince stumbled into his room at the beach house, he'd managed to put down a solid eight beers through the course of the evening. This placed him well behind the rest of the drinkers, who had completed Violet's centennial club then immediately switched to a different drinking activity, yet still left him buzzed without pushing him into the realm of being a useless vomiting heap on the bathroom floor. It was that gentle place of intoxication where everything is pleasant and the nausea is more fun than worrying. He opened the door, expecting to tumble into his bed and allow the ever-increasing sleepiness to whisk him away from his overworked consciousness. Instead what greeted him as he stepped through the door was a soft pair of lips pressing furtively against his own, filling his mouth with a familiar taste.

Dimly he registered hearing the door close behind him as he was led firmly toward the bed, however Vince suspected sleep was no longer the primary objective. Not that it would have come easily anyway; the deft hands that were running across his body had wiped away his drowsiness and left tingles of anticipation in its place. With no small effort, Vince rallied his self-control and freed his tongue for the purpose of speaking.

"Sasha, I-"

"I know," she interrupted, her breath heavy. She looked like she'd been readying herself for bed; a thin pink t-shirt and a pair grey sweats were draped across her body, creating an all-too thin layer of separation between them. "I know you haven't made your choice. I know you aren't sure what you want. That isn't what this is about." She pressed against him and worked her hand under his shirt, her nails trailing lightly as they rose up his back.

"How can this not be about us getting back together?" He found he was having trouble remembering why he was objecting, and his beer-laden brain didn't seem eager to dig up the reason.

"Together can mean a lot of things," Sasha damn near purred, so close he could feel her breath in his ear. "This isn't the complicated one."

"Sasha, please." Vince placed his own hand on the back of her head, trying to slow her down and steady himself at the same time. "I need to understand."

Sasha pulled back a begrudging few inches with an exasperated huff. “For fuck’s sake, Vince, what is so hard to grasp? I MISS you. Yes, I want to be together again, but I also miss the way you smell and taste and feel. I miss holding your hand. I miss laying naked and exhausted next you. I told you I wanted to be together as a couple and I meant it, but don’t you miss being physically engaged with one another?”

“I do,” Vince admitted. “And I miss you, too. I’ve missed you all year long.”

“You don’t have to anymore.” Sasha pushed closer to Vince once more, this time with less furtive vigor and more careful delicacy. Her kiss was almost more a brushing against his lips at first, then as she drew nearer the force slowly grew.

Vince’s head swam, an unexpected cocktail of hormones, vodka, and beer all catalyzing into a mind-dissolving acid that was rapidly destroying his capacity for rational thought. He knew what he wanted to do - dear lord it was hard to focus on anything besides that - but he didn’t know if it was the right thing. Some part of him, a rapidly growing one at that, screamed that he could figure that out later. Sasha wanted this. He wanted this. It didn’t carry any implications about his choice. What could be wrong with giving in to some physical comfort?

\* \* \*

“Promise me you’ll be here when I wake up.” Vince’s voice was still weak; the smoke’s damage to his vocal chords would likely have left him with a permanent rasp in other circumstances. His eyes, in contrast, were unyielding, staring up at her with absolute need.

She smiled and leaned down, giving him a careful kiss. It was strange that he never saw her apply anything to her lips, yet they still always tasted like cherries and root beer. He never would have imagined that combination before, now Vince couldn’t picture a world without it. Her dark curls tumbled against one of the burns on his face and he winced involuntarily, breaking their embrace.

“I’ll be here. You think I’m not going to stick around to make sure you’re okay? Give me a little credit here, Tights.”

Vince squeezed her hand with as much strength as he had, which was very little. “Thank you. For everything.”

\* \* \*

"I can't." Vince pulled away, the jerking motion pushing him from a pleasant head swim into momentary disorientation. "I'm sorry, Sasha, I can't. Even if you say this doesn't impact my other decision, that's not true. If I stay with you tonight, then we're going to get back together. I know myself well enough to know I won't be able to say no."

"But... oh. So, I guess you already have an answer for me then."

Vince nodded slowly, both out of respect to the importance of the situation and to let his brain regain its grasp on proper motion. "I'm sorry."

"It's... I guess I won't say it's okay, because we both know that isn't true, but I understand. We had a lot come between us since last year. I get why you wouldn't want to be with me anymore."

"No, Sasha, it's not that. I want to be with you. I want to be with you so bad that I'm barely able to say all this. I've just come to terms with the fact that I wasn't ready for another relationship. Some of my wounds from the last one still haven't healed all the way."

Sasha let out a harsh snort of a laugh. "Fucking A, you're giving me the 'it's not you, it's me' speech?"

"The what?" Vince's knitted eyebrows and tilted head told all the story she needed to hear. Sometimes it was easy to forget that he'd grown up without the usual cultural experiences, like sitcoms or dating. Not to mention the fact that he was so stupidly honest. It was a bit maddening; however, it seemed that he truly meant what he said - the issues were his own, not with her.

"Never mind." She moved a few feet away, trying to quiet her body's vocal cries to keep at it until he touched her in all the ways she could remember too damned clearly. "This girl from your past, was it the one who took your v-card?"

"Yes. She was my first."

"Must have been one hell of a lay. Sorry, sorry, I knew that was too much as soon as I said it." She knit her hands together to stop them from trying to mosey across the divide between them. "So, I guess we're just classmates now."

"I like to think of us as friends."

“Friends.” Of course he didn’t know how hard that would be. He hadn’t been down this road like everyone else. He was like a child in so many ways, seeing only possibilities where everyone else had already tasted bitter failure. He had no idea what he was asking, of her or of himself. He didn’t know the odds of them being able to make that transition were staggeringly low. He just believed it was doable, like he believed in so much other stupid bullshit. Yet he was always so goddamned happy. No one else she'd ever met was able to move through life the way he did, with surety at every decision and optimism at every outcome. So, maybe there was something to be said for taking the long shots after all. Perhaps stupid bullshit deserved a chance, if only once in a while.

“I think we can manage that,” she said, giving him an earnest smile.

## 144.

The return of the students, both normal and members of the HCP, marked the final chunk of the school year, with only nominal holidays to break up the work until summer vacation. The home stretch was a time when most hurriedly attacked their books in an often-futile effort to raise their grades before final exams. In the HCP it was much the same, and added into that frenzy of studying they also honed their respective skills. The final match was approaching, and it didn't require a genius to figure out it would likely be a large part of the test to determine who would advance to next year. With Michael Clark gone, there were twenty-seven students remaining, all competing for the twenty spots in the junior year class. Even assuming no former students managed to snare a space, that left a best case scenario of losing seven classmates.

It was a trial by fire, an emotional wringer that would test even the closest of friendships. The system had been designed not only knowing that, but expecting it. The goal was, after all, to create Heroes that were able to rise to any challenge and not falter in the clutch. Of course, there were other challenges to meet along the way, and as the students stumbled back onto campus in droves, one pair of chaperones was dealing with theirs.

"While I can certainly appreciate Ms. Robbins' intentions, encouraging the foliage to grow in such a manner has caused no end of trouble for the park officials," Dean Blaine said, reading through one of many folders piled up on his desk. "Were you aware that shrubbery can grow so thick that the only efficient way to get through it is with a flamethrower? I was not, but now I have ample complaint letters detailing how that process works."

"Candi didn't mean for it go on like that," Mary defended. "I talked to her, and she was just settling a debate on whether plants had ambitions or not. Admittedly, it got out of hand."

"That is a spectacular understatement if ever I've heard one. Of course, it still isn't as troublesome as having the very river you were on suddenly alter its course."

"That one is my fault," Chad said. "I had Walter shift the flow to take care of a different problem."

“Ah, you mean the twenty-foot blazing pillar that manifested in the middle of a clearing?”

“That would be the one.”

“I suppose that is the lesser of two evils,” Dean Blaine admitted, shuffling to a different folder. “On the plus side, you seem to have gotten through without losing any students or allowing anyone to sustain serious injury. That much can be commended, especially since there are no healers in that class to cover up transgressions. Two years in a row; I suppose that makes it a hot streak.”

“There were injuries on the trip before ours?” Mary asked.

“And the year before that, and the year before, etcetera. Occasionally we get a good year, such as the one where Ms. DeSoto imposed her unusual brand of authority and kept people safe, but two in a row is quite rare.”

“Actually, Angela gave me several pointers of how to keep things from getting out of hand,” Chad said. “So in a way she’s partially responsible for both years.”

“Quite a humorous turn of events, seeing as she was the one responsible for the injury when she was a freshman.”

“Angela got hurt?” Mary asked. Dean Blaine and Chad immediately exchanged a poorly-disguised grin. She felt the tips of her ears turn red. Being a telepath meant not often being out of the loop. Two years ago she would have done near anything not to have other people’s thoughts buzzing about in her brain, but now it was quite annoying to sit next to these two pillars of mental silence.

“Very much the opposite. She got into what she would eventually describe as a ‘light tussle’ and caused broken bones in several of her classmates.”

“Angela is very strong,” Chad added for emphasis.

“I suppose that does make more sense,” Mary said, still a bit begrudging about their inside chuckle at her expense. “So, are we in trouble?”

Dean Blaine blinked a few times in surprise. “What on earth for?”

“All the problems. The fire, the river, the super-growing grass.”

“Heavens no, you did exactly what you were supposed to do. You



solved problems as they arose and kept all of your charges safe. Forgive my brusque demeanor: I only needed to get some clarification around the incidents for my reports. Truth be told, you both did an exceptional job.”

“We did?”

“We did,” Chad assured her. “Really anytime there’s not a giant catastrophe involving the HCP interacting with the real world it’s considered a win. A bunch of competitive people with high-level abilities tossed into a social environment is often the recipe for some serious public gaffes.”

“You’d think I’d have heard more about that sort of thing.”

“We have an excellent PR department,” Dean Blaine explained. “Luckily it seems they will not be needed for this year’s trip. I do still have a good bit of paperwork to do, so while I appreciate you two coming down, I’m afraid I must politely request you head out.”

“Sure,” Mary said, she and Chad both rising from their seats. “Hey, Dean Blaine?”

“Yes?”

“I’ve noticed a lot of activities between the sophomores and the freshman. The party in November, chaperoning the river trip, helping with the carnival at the end of the year, all that stuff. There doesn’t seem to be as much interaction between the other classes. Do we start doing events with the seniors once we become juniors?”

“Sadly, you do not,” Dean Blaine replied. “Once you enter your third year in the Hero Certification Program, the demands on your time increase significantly, as do the tasks required of you. We try to add a little fun to the earlier years when we can, specifically because of how arduous the program becomes.”

“So this is the last year of fun?”

“Certainly not. It’s just the last year you’ll be able to view your classmates the same way. From here on it will be nearly impossible to ignore the truth of your situation: that every one of your friends is battling against you for a dream only a select few of you will get to realize. Casual socialization becomes much harder when done in the light of those circumstances.”

“Oh,” Mary said, not quite sure what to say or feel about Dean

Blaine's statement. He wasn't wrong, that much was obvious, but she hadn't really taken the time to think about it like that. As she and Chad left the office, closing the door behind her, the blonde boy gave her a courtesy nod then headed off toward the gym. In that moment Mary realized something else she hadn't picked up on before.

That was how Chad had been looking at all of them from the very beginning.

## 145.

“And that’s... how you fucking... do it!”

Roy’s voice echoed through the nearly empty gym: only the equipment and Professor Fletcher were around to provide acoustic absorption. He dropped the weights, one thousand pounds per hand, to the ground in a concrete-cracking clatter. The ultra-dense dumbbells sent up a cloud of fine dust that drifted upward, almost all the way to Roy’s beaming grin.

“Seven reps. You definitely broke through that wall of yours.” Professor Fletcher’s face was hard to read, but if Roy had taken a stab in the dark, he would have gone with curiosity as the emotion of the moment. He had no idea how right he was, or how embarrassed Professor Fletcher would have been if he’d known it was showing. “And that big of an increase in only a week. That must have been some incredible training.”

“Was it ever. Totally worth every minute of it.” Roy was glad he could say this with honesty. Although Hershel had done the lion’s share of the work over break, he knew his brother had no regrets about the effort spent. He could still feel the pride practically glowing off the memories at the end of each day. Hershel was finally a part of being a Super, and for that he would have suffered hundreds of times as much pain as a few stiff muscles.

“I’m impressed,” Professor Fletcher finally admitted. “With a few months until your final match, if you continue to improve at this pace, I expect you’ll put on quite a show.”

Roy nodded solemnly. This was their first day back from spring break, and at the entrance had been the usual nonchalant piece of paper announcing a match. The worrying thing was that this time it was only a date, May 20. There were no lineups listed. It was possible they’d left them off because there was only one more unique combination of adversaries to pit against each other, but somehow no one was quite willing to bank on that theory. Nearly two years in the HCP had taught them to avoid assumptions. It was best to go in ready for anything.

“I’m going to try my best. Actually, that’s part of what I wanted to talk to you about.”

“Oh?”

“Yeah, I wanted to see if you could help me come up with an exercise regime that would really push someone who is out of shape. Nothing too dangerous, just enough to make sure they are constantly hitting their limits.”

“Given the fact that you are several hundred pounds of relatively solid muscle and just curled a literal ton of weight, I’m guessing this isn’t for you,” Professor Fletcher speculated.

“No, sir. Actually, it’s for Hershel.”

“Is it now? While I can appreciate your concern for your brother’s health, especially given how he thought you would react to your trip, I’m afraid my time is supposed to be dedicated to helping those actually in the program.”

“It does help me,” Roy protested. “Look, it’s a little complicated, but I promise, this is part of my training.”

“How about you uncomplicate it and we’ll go from there?”

\* \* \*

Vince thought he was the first one done with class on Mondays, so he was surprised to come back and find Nick sitting in the living room. He was reclined in a chair facing the television, and from the way his sunglasses sat slightly skewed, Vince wondered if he was taking a nap. Taking care to be quiet, Vince headed over to the boys’ side door.

“Good first day back?”

“Yeah. You?”

“Depends, is it your first day if you skip all of your classes? Aside from the HCP ones, of course.” Nick’s tone was distant, one he’d chosen specifically for this performance.

Vince shrugged off his backpack and let it settle to the ground. This was a new mood from Nick, and that usually meant things were going to get interesting. “Why’d you skip your classes?”

“Let me answer your question to my question with a question. Did you see the announcement?”

“Yeah, final match is in May.”

“Then, given that it is currently late March, you can probably take a

good guess at why I skipped my classes today.” Nick jerked himself out of the chair and took a few steps away, simultaneously smoothing out his hair and straightening his sunglasses. “I’ve had a rather unexpected hitch thrown into our plans. All my previous months’ efforts have been devising a myriad of strategies to use against Team Three. The sheet didn’t announce any such match up, which means I now have to account for how we would beat Two, Three, Four, or any strange combination of them, not to mention factoring in surprise elements like the potential of shifting a Captain’s team members at the last minute.”

“Are you okay? You seem stressed.”

“Wouldn’t you be?”

“Sure, but that’s me. You’re very rarely stressed, and even less rarely do you show it.”

Nick let out a long sigh and desperately wished this character smoked. It would have made such a nice touch. “Damn your bouts of perception. Yes, I am stressed, because while I expected some sort of monkey wrench, I wasn’t quite prepared for no direction at all. It invalidates all logical planning. No team can realistically prep for every scenario.”

“It’ll be okay, Nick,” Vince assured him. “We’re a strong team, and we’ve only gotten better through the year. You’ve helped us get further than we would have without you. Just believe in the team and think of some fluid strategies like you did for the first one.”

“The first one had parameters, Vince, even if they were only knowing who we would face. I will give you that we have a solid team, much better than we did at the beginning of the year. For the most part everyone pulls their weight.”

Vince rolled his eyes. “For the most part? It’s okay to be positive, you know? I can’t think of anyone who doesn’t give their all.”

“I can,” Nick replied immediately. “You.”

“I... excuse me?”

“You. You don’t do your best. You don’t pull your weight. In our span at Lander you have won two, count them, two fights. Thomas in freshman year and Michael in our first match this year. Congratulations, that makes you tied with me.”

“But-”

“And that’s not even mentioning how long it took you to actually start using your power. Even now I bet you’ve only got that leftover forest fire and maybe a car battery’s worth of electricity inside you. Then there’s your supposedly new weapon, kinetic energy. Have you done any training that I didn’t lead you in? I’ll take anything, even a game of catch against a wall. Anything?”

“I... no. I haven’t.”

“I know you haven’t because I know you.” Nick ran his hands through his hair again, giving the illusion that he was calming himself down. “Vince, you’re one of my best friends and you’re probably the most selfless and loyal person I’ve ever met, but you’re always fucking terrified of going all out. From day one you might have been one of the strongest people here, yet your record is shit because while the rest of us are pushing our limits, you haven’t even tested yours. And that’s why I tell you all this now. You need to push yourself. I need you to push yourself. Because this last match is going to be the big one, and if we fall short, I’m positive that this dormitory will have some vacancies next year.”

Vince’s gaze had been drifting toward the floor, but at Nick’s final words, his demeanor grew stiff and his eyes rose. “Why? Our team has a win and a tie.”

“By hook, crook, and skin of our teeth. We’ve done well, but not amazing. And remember, they don’t move us up as a team. A few of us would get through, but as for the others, they’re at risk. If we don’t kick as much ass as physically possible on that last match then that will be the end for some of our friends. We can’t be good anymore. We have to be goddamn unstoppable.”

Nick analyzed his friend’s posture carefully, noticing the gentle gripping of his fists and the way his feet naturally shifted into a balanced stance. He’d seen it a precious few times before: it was the stance Vince took when he was pushed far enough to get serious. Of course, he would only reach that point when his friends were in danger, hence Nick’s theatrics. He needn’t have bothered with all the analytical effort. The depth of Vince’s resolve spilled out from his voice in glorious waves.

“Tell me what we need to do.”

## 146.

“Welcome, all, to this week’s meeting of The Loyal Order of the Water Buffaloes.” Nick stood before his teammates, hands spread open in a welcoming manner. They were huddled in the common room, their default meeting place, for what Nick had called a “necessary tactics overview conclave.” Mary had sent the texts and the people had rallied. Nick stood there, waiting for some reaction to his announcement, before finally giving up and dropping his arms.

“Really? No one here watched The Flintstones as a kid? I’m the only one?”

“Hermit,” Mary said with a shrug.

“Wanderer,” Vince added.

“My parents didn’t have cable,” Alex chimed in.

Nick turned to the remaining three, who stared right back at him.

“What?” Alice said at last. “Not everybody remembers random details from cartoons in their childhood. So yes, you are the weirdo.”

“Well damn. Fine then, since you all want to be spoilsports, I guess we’ll actually get right down to business.” Nick’s tone was flippant but he still looked oddly disappointed that no one had gotten his joke. “I’m sure you all noticed the notice this morning, and have all come to the conclusion that a lack of listed matches means we have no idea what to expect. I’ve given the matter ample thought, and after speaking to our dear telekinetic captain for approval, have designed a training regimen that I feel will best prepare us for whatever the challenge might be.”

“This ought to be interesting,” Roy chuckled. “You going to pull out more playing cards?”

“No need. The concept for this two-month stretch is simple enough that it requires no visual illustration. To put it simply, we will be training in pairs. You, for example, will be spending your free time fighting Vince.”

“Whoa now, I’ve already got a lot of training to catch up on, and no offense, but I don’t think fighting him would be as beneficial.”

“As beneficial as what? Weight lifting? I’m glad you found a way to

advance yourself, but you do realize you were already able to pick up more than almost anyone else in our class, right? Raw hitting power is an important part of your arsenal, but it's not the piece that's most lacking right now," Nick countered.

"Then what is?"

"Control. You're so goddamned strong that we can't fully utilize you. You ever wonder why surgeons don't use a katana to operate? In terms of sheer cutting it's far more effective than a scalpel."

"Because they need precision," Roy said, his lips thin. He didn't like being talked down to, but Roy was astute enough to know that Nick rarely went on these tangents without a point.

"Exactly. The only people you really can fight against are ones like Chad, who you don't have to hold back against. Everyone else is just a matter of you catching them and breaking their limbs. It's fine for some one on one, but eventually you'll need to take on multiple people and be able to punch just hard enough to take them down without killing them. That's why you'll be sparring Vince. He's a better fighter than you, but if you hit too hard you can seriously hurt him. For his part, training against someone with your strength will put real risk on the line, so hopefully he'll get his shit together with the kinetic absorption."

Roy glanced over at Vince. He hadn't taken into account the risk his teammate would be taking by training with someone like him. Roy expected to see uncertainty or worry in his friend's crisp blue eyes. All he found was restless determination. Vince wasn't afraid to spar Roy: he was excited about it. He looked like he would start fighting right now if Nick gave the go ahead. Roy had seen Vince when he got serious; it meant the taller boy shouldn't take their matches lightly.

"Okay. I'm in," Roy said at last.

"Glad to hear it," Nick said, turning back to the room at large. "Next up will be Alex, Mary, and Alice. I know I said pairs, but there's seven of us so one team had to be bigger."

"Why us three? Not objecting, just wondering what I'm supposed to be focusing on," Alice said.

"A fair question. You three are put together because you and Mary need to work on your delicacy. Both of you have ample force in your powers,



but neither of you have anything near the level of precision that Alex does. For his part, he needs to up his force a good bit, and training against a pair of people that can accidentally tear him limb from limb should improve his raw power considerably.”

“Hang on, if those are the teams then doesn’t that make the last one you and Camille?” Vince said, the process of elimination making the last pairing quite clear.

“Indeed,” Nick confirmed. “She and I are similar in that we both fight from a place of weakness. Neither of us is particularly tall or strong, at least in relation to other people in the HCP. We have different styles, however, so sparring and learning from one another should significantly expand both of our repertoires.”

“If Vince is in constant risk of getting his bones broken, shouldn’t I be somewhere on hand when they fight?” Camille pointed out.

“Absolutely not. The whole point of their training is to gain understanding about the consequences of failure. Roy will seriously hurt a friend if he hits too hard. Vince will get significant injuries if he doesn’t learn to absorb blows. If we remove pain as an instructor, we reduce the effectiveness of their efforts.”

“Don’t worry,” Vince told her. “I’m not going to get hurt.”

“You? I’m fighting the strongest girl in the class and someone who can bend gravity to their will,” Alex pointed out. “How about a little concern over here?”

“Yeah, I’m more worried about taking on two people with a lifetime practicing their power instead of months,” Alice joined in.

“Listen everyone, I know this seems a little intense, and in truth it probably will be.” Mary stood from her seat to address her team, not that it made much difference. “I had a long talk with Nick before I agreed to this and I had those same concerns. The truth of the matter is that he’s right. Fighting people who have what we lack will be the fastest path to rounding each one of us out. Since we have no idea what the last test will be, increasing our various skills will give us an element of surprise and the ability to splinter off as needed.”

Mary took a breath to steady herself. It had been jarring that afternoon when Nick told her what was really on the line. “We’re going to win. We’re

going to show everyone that we belong here.” Her eyes might have flicked tellingly to Vince, but if so, no one other than Nick noticed.

“We have to.”

## 147.

Fighting Vince was infuriating. In his time at Lander, Roy had fought people who were more skilled than he was, faster than he was, and had unexpected talents he couldn't utilize, but he'd never encountered someone quite like Vince. For one thing, the silver-haired young man could predict movements with startling accuracy. It was different than Chad's method, where he reacted instantly thanks to his accelerated brain. Vince didn't seem to react at all: instead he anticipated. By the time Roy's attacks were close enough to touch him, Vince had already deflected or dodged them and begun a counter. He'd talked about being trained since he was a child, but Roy had never taken the time to appreciate just how much ability came with that sort of dedication. By the end of the first day it was clear that, from a technical perspective, Vince's level of skill was something Roy would likely never achieve.

Of course, none of that mattered in a real fight, where Vince's deflections and attacks would fail miserably against his opponent's ridiculous strength. That was the even more annoying part for Roy, knowing that if he let loose he could win, and then having to hold himself back. Not that his attempts were entirely successful; within the first week he accidentally broke Vince's right arm twice and cracked a few of his ribs.

Camille had not been pleased.

By the time the third week rolled around, Roy's control had progressed enough to where fractured bones were more exception than expectation, though Camille was still taking a lot of bruises off Vince at the end of each session. Roy had to admit, despite his initial hesitance to spend what little free time he had in this endeavor, it was generating noticeable results. He was getting better at fighting someone who wasn't super tough, and he was slowly learning how to take on yet another type of opponent. The training was paying off... for him.

"Oooof." Vince's breath flew out of him as Roy punched a little too hard, broke his guard, and sent a fist deep into his torso. The smaller boy collapsed to the ground as he struggled to get air into his lungs. Roy took a few steps back so as to allow his friend time to recover. He'd gotten the wind knocked out of him a few times by Chad, he knew it was a very unpleasant experience.

“You okay?” Roy asked once Vince’s frantic gasping had become less shallow.

“Been... better,” Vince panted. “Been... worse... too.”

“I hear that.” Roy hunkered into a squatting position while he waited; it seemed like Vince was still going to need a bit before he was ready to go again. “I have to ask something, and for once I don’t mean to be an ass about it. Are you sure you can absorb punches?”

“In theory,” Vince replied, his words steady along with his inhalation of oxygen. “I’ve gotten a tennis ball or two.”

“Yeah, but a fist is a fair bit stronger. Especially mine. I just felt like I should bring it up, because it’s been nearly a month and you haven’t absorbed even one yet.”

“I know. Trust me, I know. I’m still trying to figure out the knack for it.”

“The knack?”

Vince nodded, rocking back to a sitting position instead of staying on his hands and knees. “Every type of energy is a little different. When I absorb or shoot something unintentionally it’s all instinct, but to do it with reliability, I have to find out what strategy works best.”

“You lost me.”

“It’s hard to explain if you don’t have this type of ability, but electricity is probably the best example. Remember how I couldn’t get it to shoot straight over more than a few inches all last year?”

“I remember you frying the electrical system during our first ranged training,” Roy reminded him.

“Right. Well, in working with Professor Fletcher, I realized the problem was that I was trying to shoot it like I did fire. Flames are easy: you just point them and let rip. Electricity is trickier. If I just blast away then I get the splitting issue.”

“So how do you shoot lighting?”

“I picture the spot I want it to hit, focusing on all the electricity inside of me and how little there is in that object by comparison. I think of it as a giant imbalance, so when I strike all I’m doing is creating a link to achieve

evenness.”

“Huh. Sounds complicated.”

“A little, but it’s what works for me. Others might do it differently. Anyway, the point is that every energy has a subtle variety, and finding the knack is just me figuring out how to interact with it.”

“Not to rush your process, but you might want to step it up on figuring out kinetic energy. We don’t have a shitload of time left.”

“I know,” Vince sighed. “I’ve been trying everything I can think of, but none of it is working. I still don’t know how I took the energy out of that table, or the tennis balls.”

“No clue on the balls, but the table is obvious: instinct. You did it because you had to do it, otherwise it would have wrecked you.”

“Probably,” Vince agreed. “Too bad I can’t get the same instinct when sparring.”

“Maybe you can,” Roy said, standing back up. Vince followed suit and the two moved back toward the area they’d been training in. “I have an idea. Don’t fight me anymore, just block.”

“What will that do?”

“On its own, nothing,” Roy admitted. “But there’s another piece to this. I’m going to try and break your arms.”

“Excuse me?”

“That’s why I don’t want you dodging or deflecting. Take the blows. This is going to help me learn how strong my punches need to be to just barely break bone.”

“I see. So either I absorb the energy, or I get a shattered arm.”

“Yup. Let’s see if your self-preservation instinct kicks in after a few fractures.”

Vince started to object, on grounds of basic sanity, then thought better of it. Roy was right: he didn’t have many weeks left, and mastering a new technique was time consuming. If he could do this, it would mean a whole new dimension to his fighting abilities. A skill like this could easily be the difference between a win and a loss. His team needed him to be stronger.

Vince was not going to let one of his friends get booted, not because of him. He raised his arms into a basic guard position.

“Whenever you’re ready.”

## 148.

“Are there any more questions?”

The group fidgeted on the mismatched furniture, no one wanting to speak without having something important to say. They still lived in the seemingly abandoned building where they had been for nearly a year now, but it seemed that was soon to change. For some, like the dark-haired man with the sharp features, it was a welcome relief. Others, like the boy who couldn't possibly be any older than twelve, were clearly dismayed by the sudden change.

The next to speak was a slim blonde woman with elfin features and her blonde hair trimmed in a pixie cut. “I still don't think it's smart for you to travel in the open. You can stay holed up here until we're ready to act, then let me transport you.”

The dark-haired man in the red coat pressed his right ring and index finger to his temple. He rarely did anything with the left hand, the one concealed behind several layers of cloth and gloves, unless it was necessary.

“Then how would we get away? Part of why we're going now is to lay the ground work for our escape. And before you offer to help with that too, let me remind you that at this stage we don't want them to even know we have a teleporter, let alone that it's you.”

“They wouldn't have to know.”

“Shims, when this is over, we're going to have a lot of people after us, and while you are effective as hell, you are also very distinctive.”

The delicate-featured woman leaned back in her chair, unhappy but unable to think of another solid objection. Luckily, a different female, one whose hair was styled into short dark spikes, suffered no such obstacle.

“I'd like to call bullshit on not bringing anyone besides yourself, Persephone, and Gerard. Why not let me into the lineup?”

“Because no one knows about you either,” the man said, his tone surprisingly patient given the number of times he'd heard some manifestation of this argument. “Persephone was made in last year's extraction attempts, George was given instructions to lead his interrogators down the path to Gerard's involvement, and as for me, well, we've already been over this. I

refuse to open it for debate once more.”

“I could help.”

“I know you could, Joan, and you will. This is one step in a long journey. Everyone here wants to pitch in or they wouldn’t have signed up. We have limited resources and opportunities, however, so the more we can keep close to the vest, the greater our options are in days that follow. Trust me.”

Joan grumbled something unintelligible but allowed herself to fall silent. She did trust him. All of them did. He’d pulled them together, shown them they weren’t alone. He’d given them a purpose, traded all the bitter disappointment in their guts for a dream that burned brightly through their minds.

“Okay, last chance for questions. Quentin? Gerard? Anything?”

The sharp-faced man and the boy both shook their heads no.

“Then with that I think we can call this meeting adjourned.” He rose from his seat quickly, strong legs lifting him into the air as though they couldn’t bear the idea of restrained for much longer. “I don’t know about you folks, but I’m going to get a head start on packing.”

He headed through the north door, leading into a small area populated only by himself. Gerard got up and followed suit, with Quentin a few steps behind. The women were a bit slower, so everyone else was out of earshot when Joan asked her question.

“Why does he call you Shims?”

Shims took a moment to answer, pulling herself from her chair and smoothing out the linen pants encircling her legs. “It’s short for my codename. He’s always had a penchant for nicknames.”

“No, that part I knew,” Joan said. “I mean why are you the only one he still calls by any form of their Hero name? He doesn’t call Persephone Mood Swing, or George Relentless Steel, or Gerard Raze. You’re the only one he doesn’t address by their real name.”

“It’s because she hasn’t left that life,” Persephone said, fielding the question before the other woman had a chance. “The rest of us aren’t Heroes anymore. She still is.”

“Still seems odd,” Joan remarked. She didn’t press the issue,



thankfully, instead heading off to the section of the warehouse that constituted her room.

“Thanks,” Shims said once Joan was gone.

“Don’t worry about it,” Persephone reassured her. “Try not to fault her for asking. For someone who wasn’t in the HCP, it seems like an innocent question.”

“I’m not the one who should be offended. She makes a good point, you know. I’m sure he would call you by your old name if you asked him.”

“I know he would. I just don’t want him to. That’s part of my past life. Besides, despite everything that happened, I still have a lot of respect for the program. It feels wrong to use a name given to me for the sake of maintaining the law while we’re conspiring to break it.”

“I must admit, I didn’t see this coming when I graduated,” Shims said, a memory from a faraway life glimmering in her eyes.

“None of us did. Hell, I don’t think a single one of my expectations panned out,” Persephone said. “Sort of makes you wish you could go back and do it all over, but this time get things right.”

“I don’t know. If I could change the past, I’m not sure I would. It might make things better, but then again, there are worse possible realities than this one.”

“Hard to imagine how things could be much worse.”

“No, it isn’t,” Shims disputed. “Just imagine a world without him in it.” With that she walked out of the makeshift living room, leaving Persephone alone with the mismatched furniture.

“Yeah,” Persephone said to no one. “I guess that would be pretty bad.”

## 149.

“That’s all for today’s class,” Professor Pendleton said, dismissing his charges. “If I could have Alice, Nick, Will, Britney, and Tiffani stay after for a few minutes; the rest of you are free to leave.”

His announcement was followed by the weary shuffle of papers and feet that accompanied the end of every particularly draining class. Much as the year before, the nearer the end drew, the harder the instructors seemed to be driving their students. It was crunch time, though whether the thing being crunched was their days or their brains no student could have readily told you.

The five Professor Pendleton had named stayed behind, clustering around his desk while the remaining students exited. He waited until the last one was gone, and then a few minutes further, before revealing the purpose in their after-class meeting.

“You five are the ones who qualified for the extra credit tailing assignment,” Professor Pendleton informed them. “Given your marks in my class, I’m sure most of you already figured that out.” His eyes might have flicked to Alice at the word “most.” If so, no one was crass enough to make note of it. “I apologize for the delay in organizing this; it has taken me a bit longer than anticipated to get my plan approved.”

He reached into his desk and produced a series of five white envelopes, laying them in a row in front of him. They bore no names or any other distinctive marks, nothing at all to distinguish one from the other.

“These will be your starting locations. Pick one, and be there Friday at seven in the evening. If you are late, you forfeit. You’ll all have different spots, and they will each have a vantage point that allows you to see me. I am the target of the assignment. You’ll have to tail me for one hour. Once I reach my endpoint I’ll sit down. Anyone who comes up to me while I’m sitting is considered to have passed. I’ll give you all until eight fifteen to reach me, in case some of you employ more long-ranged techniques. Questions so far?”

“Yeah, why start us at a distance? We could just run up to you and stay close for the entire hour,” Alice pointed out.

“Ah yes, thank you for leading me to my next rule. Since the essence of tailing lies in not being seen, we’re going to impose a catching disqualification. Now, I obviously know you’re all following me, so the rule

is a little more simplified. If I lay a hand on you, you are out. I'm starting you at a distance for the sake of fairness. Me getting close enough to touch one of you means you've not only lost me, but been circled back on by me. If that isn't the essence of failure while tailing someone then I would struggle to think of a better definition."

"So you're going to chase us?" Britney asked.

"Not overtly. This is a public area and I have no intention of making a scene. Consider this: if you are able to stay well enough concealed while tracking me then I will never have the opportunity to catch you."

"You make it sound easy, but you're a specialist at this stuff," Alice said.

"Of course it's not easy," Professor Pendleton said, stifling an exasperated sigh. "This is a trial that takes the place of your final exam, should you pass. It should be goddamned near impossible given your levels of skill. Admittedly, so should achieving the point totals that got you here. Maybe one or two of you will pull it off; however, please don't be under the impression that I'm expecting any of you to succeed."

"There's one thing you haven't covered yet," Nick said, shifting slightly toward the front of the group.

"Do tell."

"Abilities. You haven't said whether we can use our powers in the course of your trial."

Professor Pendleton greeted his protégé's questions with a curiously over-sized smile. "This is the Hero Certification Program, is it not? Of course you can use your abilities; learning to apply them to various tasks is the entire point of you all being here."

A small wave of optimism seemed to wash across the group; several of them had been wondering how they would have a hope of success. Adding back in the option of their powers made it seem like they had a shot. Nick was, strangely, the only one who seemed unhappy with this news.

"So, we're learning to tail people, incorporating our abilities as Supers?"

"I believe I just said that, yes."

“And if it so happens that our target is a Super as well?”

“Then of course you could expect him to utilize his powers too,” Professor Pendleton tossed back.

The cautious optimism that had permeated the students came crashing down. In all his lessons, in all their classes, Professor Pendleton had still not shown them what his ability was. Very few of the instructors had, actually. Aside from Professor Fletcher, Professor Stone, and Professor Hill, the rest of the Lander educating staff had not used a single ability as far as the students could tell. In most cases it led a sense of curiosity. In this situation it meant they had likely already failed his test before even taking it.

“It seems like you could at least tell us what your power is,” Alice said. “You know all of ours, and you can take steps to defend against them. Shouldn’t we get equal ground?”

“Miss Adair, is it your understanding that Heroes are generally low-profile individuals?” Professor Pendleton asked.

“Not particularly.”

“So you see how my being forearmed with knowledge is quite appropriate. Were I to spot you, I would have a full suite of information about your skills thanks to media’s love affair with our occupation.”

“But obviously we’d have at least some advanced information on a target we were tailing.”

This time it was Will, not the instructor, who corrected her.

“From who? This is the Subtlety major. We’re the ones who do the scouting and information gathering. We’re the ones who find out what a person can do so we can warn the other Heroes. Professor Pendleton is right: if we graduate with our major in Subtlety then this is a real world situation we can expect to see a lot of.”

“Well said, Mr. Murray. Very well said, in fact. With that, we have covered all the ground rules and I am done with questions. Be at your starting points promptly at seven.”

The students gathered their things and began to leave. As they reached the exit, Professor Pendleton called after them with one last snippet.

“Oh, and I nearly forgot. Good luck to you all. You’ll need it.”



The knock on Nick's door came around eight that evening. He glanced up from his computer and looked over. Her self-control was impressive; he'd expected her to arrive hours earlier. Instead of getting out of his chair Nick yelled over his shoulder.

"We both know you can open the door yourself."

There was a pause, then a soft buzz as his door opened to reveal Alice, clad in sweats and clearly stressed, at least judging from the state of her tangled hair and the nervous fidgeting she was unconsciously doing.

"I guess that's my fault for letting you find out," she said, walking in and shutting the door.

"And for copying my work in the first place," Nick added. "Which, in retrospect, was a pretty impressive piece of misdirection."

"I aim to please." She hopped on the bed without any sense of self-consciousness. Nick wondered if he'd ever had people in his life less aware of social implications than his dorm-mates. Where he was from, coming to a man's room and getting on his bed carried certain intentions, ones he was relatively certain Alice wasn't intentionally communicating. Not yet, anyway.

"I'd say you're probably wondering why I'm here, but since it's you, I bet you already know."

"Sexual ravishing?"

"You always swing for the fences, I'll give you that," Alice replied.

"Can't blame a guy for trying. Anyway, yes, I know you're here because you think I know what Professor Pendleton's ability is."

"Wrongo. I'm here because I know that you know his power. Hell, you probably know all of our professors' abilities. I wouldn't be surprised if you knew everything down to their birthplaces and favorite colors."

"You seem to think quite highly of my investigative abilities."

"Am I wrong?"

"I didn't say that," Nick shot back. He reached around and turned off

his computer screen. The current research didn't involve Alice directly, but nevertheless, he was learning more and more that discretion around this girl could save him quite a few headaches.

"So, what can he do?"

"From what I've gathered he can teach a class fairly well, he can certainly see through people's bullshit, and he probably is a reasonably proficient gymnast."

Alice cocked her head in perplexity.

"He won a tournament when he was a teen. Plus he has excellent balance."

"Ooooookay. Interesting, and we will absolutely circle back to that last part, but not what I was talking about."

"I know what you were talking about. Let me ask you something first: you know next year we drop down to two majors, right? Are you planning on keeping Subtlety?"

Alice glanced down at the bed sheets. "I haven't really decided yet. I mean, given the whole gravity manipulation thing, I've got to keep Control, but Ranged Combat isn't all that productive for me."

"Ranged Combat isn't productive for a girl whose abilities are perfect for staying at a distance and making objects fly all over the place?"

"We learn a lot of that in Control. Besides, I didn't say I was dropping it, just that I'm not sure. I know I'm not the best at Subtlety, I just kind of hate to give it up. It's always interesting, and really, it's different from almost every other aspect of Hero duties. Once I let it go, I can't get it back, so I'm making up my mind slowly."

"I can understand that," Nick said. "So, to answer your question: no. I'm not going to tell you what Professor Pendleton's power is."

"Damn it, Nick, this is not the time to go into dickhead mode."

"Believe it or not, this is me in good friend mode," Nick countered. He plucked a pen from his desk and began twirling it between his fingers effortlessly. "If you'd told me you were going to drop Subtlety and just wanted to ace the test so the final exam wouldn't screw up your stats overall then I would have happily given you the dirt. On the other hand, if you really

do want to consider Subtlety as an option for your career as a Hero, then I'd be doing you a disservice."

"How? You can't say knowing invalidates the test, because you already know."

"I know because I found out. I did the work. You can, too, and if you do then you'll get the information. My point is that I'd help you cheat if you were just getting by, but if you want to learn then I have to say no. Professor Pendleton really did put together a great sample of a real world exercise. Yeah, you probably won't pass, but in the act of failing you'll learn some things not to do. That's all success is: screwing up over and over until you've learned the right way to do things."

"Geez, you didn't complain this much when I copied your tailing work."

"Because you earned that one. You tricked me. If you can get the information from me without my help then you deserve it. That's exactly what we're supposed to be learning to do in the first place."

"All right, I take your point. You won't help me. I'm guessing that means you won't give me any assistance in the actual trial, either."

"Not intentionally. Then again, you used some surprising levels of cunning to get here in the first place. See if you can dip into that well again, and maybe you'll find a way to outfox us all."

"Please, you don't remotely believe that," Alice said. Her posture had relaxed during their conversation. She was clearly still worried about the test, however she seemed to have reached the point of resolving herself to whatever fate had in store. It was a skill everyone in the HCP possessed, because those who couldn't turn off their frantic nerves had washed out within the first few weeks.

"No, I don't. I think you got lucky on the first one. Generally speaking, this class isn't really suited to your talents."

"Hey, I'm not an idiot. I'm just not as good at this as some of the rest of you."

"Precisely. Remember, HCP isn't looking for those who are good, they are looking for those who are the best. You have an ability that is flat-out spectacular, one that allows you to neutralize Supers with all manner of



powers. I have no doubt you'll be a serious contender for a graduation spot if you keep plugging away at the Control course."

"I guess so," Alice agreed, pulling herself off Nick's bed. "For what it's worth, I have no doubt you'll get one of the Hero spots, too. No one in our class even comes close to you in lying, cheating, or manipulating."

"You sure know how to sweet talk a fella, but only time will tell. Most graduates, even those who majored in Subtlety, have other talents they bring to the table. Punchy kinds of talents."

"Then get good at that," Alice said. "I will not accept any excuses for failure. The five of us are going all the way in this thing. We'll show everyone that Powereds can be viable candidates for Heroes after the procedure. All of us, together."

"That is a very pleasant thought," Nick concurred. "In the meantime, let's just focus on getting to next year."

"Deal," Alice said, giving him a warm smile and letting herself out.

## 151.

In her nearly two years at Lander, Alice had faced a myriad of trials: some personal, some academic, and some heroic in nature. She was far from the head-up-her-ass-princess that had rolled into Melbrook on the first day and made snap decisions about everyone around her. She'd grown in terms of capabilities, too. Her power had evolved, as well as her willingness to use it. Alice was not quite a first-class warrior, but she no longer wasted time fretting that she was a hindrance to her team. These challenges had caused her to grow, and they had taken place in all manner of locations. So it was with some surprise that she found the one that had worried her most, Professor Pendleton's tailing exam, was taking place on something of a home-turf for her.

She was standing on the third floor of a massive outdoor mall, looking down at a healthy crowd of people milling about a food court. Healthy, in this case, refers only to the size of the crowd, not their overall physical wellness. A small distinction, but given the quality of the food they were cramming down, an important one. Her green eyes darted through the people, rapidly scanning for any sign of her target. The location in her envelope had put her in front of a designer boutique on the third floor. She'd spotted Will arriving in front of a Radio Shack and Nick looking bored in front of a kiosk selling sunglasses. It seemed Professor Pendleton had decided to have a little fun with doling out their starting positions. She couldn't see Britney or Tiffani, which didn't really mean much given their respective talents. Nevertheless, it was clear that all three of the starting positions of which she was aware had only one thing in common: their view of the food court below, which was curiously still absent of Professor Pendleton.

Alice's nerves manifested in constant fidgeting with the brim of her pink and black baseball cap, an attempt to make herself less recognizable that would have fooled no one. Even with her mane of blonde hair pulled back into a ponytail and stuffed into a hat, she hadn't thought to cover her striking facial features or dress in a way that concealed her distinctive figure. None of which might be of concern if she failed to even locate her tailing target. If only she knew what his damned ability was. He might be able to change his looks, or even shift size entirely. What if he was masquerading as a child? Or a woman? Alice took a deep breath to try and calm down. If he could do those things, then she was screwed. Nothing would change that. She needed to focus on the scenarios where she had a fighting shot. Like if he was just

wearing a mundane disguise.

A quick glance told her Nick and Will were still in starting position. Good. If neither of them had found him, then he probably wasn't around to be found yet. Alice turned back to the food court, trying to let her gaze wander across everything. Assume he would be in a disguise: that was a fair bet. Okay, so if that was the case, how would she see through it? He was tall - unless it was an all-is-lost scenario there would be no way to hide that. He could hunch over, but that would draw even more attention. She let her eyes lift upward to only observe the highest human points before it dawned on her that he might be sitting.

What next? Professor Pendleton wasn't a terribly distinctive man: lean frame, clean shaven face as of that morning, dark hair, all features which he could disguise with a basic stage makeup kit, some dye, and a pillow under his shirt. It dawned on Alice that perhaps he favored his non-distinctive style specifically because it made him harder to visually pin down. Her eyes darted over to Nick, clad in a generic t-shirt, shorts, and flip-flops. Except for the glasses, he was much the same as the professor. Nothing about him really stood out. In fact, if he took off his sunglasses, Alice was reasonably sure she would lose track of him in the crowd. Maybe that was the point of them: aside from masking when he used his luck, it gave him the ability to vanish in plain sight.

Alice blinked in surprise at her own realization. That was it. That was what she should be looking for. He was already nondescript, so that's what she'd been searching faces to find. Professor Pendleton was a professional, he knew how to divert people's attention. They'd be looking for someone not worth looking at. Alice changed her strategy, letting her eyes be drawn by bright colors or unique people.

Guy in a giant eagle jacket. Not him. Girl in light pink dress and matching shoes. Not him, but Alice wondered if the girl had gotten those heels at one of the stores in the mall. Silver painted man doing the robot as people threw change into his hat. Not him. Gentleman in a crisp business suit with an electric blue tie. Not him. Young guy with spiked hair, spiked choker, and ripped t-shirt. Obviously not... him.

It would have been easy to miss, even knowing what she was looking for, but the disinterested way the punk-styled man leaned his face against his hand did more than convey a sense of boredom. It also hid his key features without seeming like it was intended to. Alice felt her heart quicken with

excitement. The lean frame, the dark hair, and even though he was leaning on the cheap plastic table, it was clear he was taller than most of the other people around him.

“Bingo,” she muttered under her breath. As if on cue, the target rose from his table, somehow always keeping a portion of his face obscured as he meandered nonchalantly through the food court. She risked a glance at her fellow test takers. Nick didn’t seem to notice anything, but with his control of body language and hidden eyes, that didn’t really tell her crap. Will was a better indicator, and despite trying to look nonplussed, his dark eyes were definitely darting in the direction of the meandering punk wannabe. Still no sign of the others, but that was enough confirmation for her.

Alice pulled down the brim of her cap and tried unsuccessfully to suppress an excited grin. Despite all the worry, despite the high stakes, despite the knowledge that there was almost no chance she would get a victory, Alice was still pumped up. Win or lose, this wasn’t going to be boring. The disguised professor was nearing the edge of the food court, heading toward an opening that led to the vast expanses of the mall’s main sector.

The game was on.

For the first half hour, Professor Pendleton played by the rules of humans. He slid effortlessly through the crowd, a disguised grace that made him nearly impossible to keep up with unless most of his pursuers were willing to shove their way through the other shoppers. This was a bigger hurdle for some than others. Nick seemed to keep pace with the same inexplicable speed, and Alice was not too shy about bullying her way past people in her way (she'd been to enough designer label releases to be well at home with this concept). Will was having a little more trouble, yet he seemed strangely unconcerned about it. The one having the biggest issue keeping up was the one who had to elbow her way through the crowd without the benefit of being seen. Britney briefly entertained the idea of going visible to make her pursuit more effective, but realized it was a poor trade off. Yes, she was a little slower than the others, but she was also the one least likely to be caught and eliminated. Besides, it wasn't like she had to keep perfect pace with the professor. When she lost sight of him all she had to do was follow the other students taking the trial. It seemed he hadn't really thought this through too well, or he would have realized that having them take the test all at once made it infinitely easier on them. So long as they kept each other in sight, the success of one was the success of all of them.

Britney managed to catch up to them outside an upscale men's clothing store. They were milling about, trying hard to look like they weren't staring at the entrance. Well, Alice and Will were. Nick seemed to have lost the trail, and of course Tiffani was even harder to find than Britney was. So logic dictated that the professor had gone inside and they were all waiting for him to emerge. Given what they sold, it seemed a fair bet that he would leave in different attire than he entered, a standard trick to throw people off one's trail. Briefly, the idea of entering the store and watching him shop entered Britney's mind; however, she banished it away almost as quickly. Without a solid frame of reference for how long he'd been in there, she could easily miss him and his exit, losing track of the others to boot. No, the smart play was to wait out here at a distance where she could resume pursuit safely. It was a good plan. Unfortunately, she hatched it at the thirty-five minute mark.

"Sorry, Britney, I'm afraid you're out," said a familiar voice just as a hand landed on her shoulder. She turned around to find Professor Pendleton looking down at her. His gaze was a bit off, which made sense when she realized he couldn't see her face. She was right that he'd changed clothes:

now he wore a button-down and a blazer, but that didn't explain how he'd managed to circle back on all of them. Of course, even that wasn't the most pressing question at hand.

"How did you find me?" Britney realized her voice was thicker than normal. She was glad no one could see her: from the warmth cascading over her skin she knew she was blushing fiercely.

"I chose an outdoor mall for a reason. For one thing, there are puddles from last night's rain storm, which still splash when you walk through them. For another, lots of open spaces where shadows can be seen. Didn't you ever notice?"

Britney looked at the ground, very confused. She didn't cast a shadow while invisible, she already knew that. As her eyes bore into the ground, she did actually notice something. There was a very minor shimmer, like a heat distortion, in the spot where he shadow should be. It was something she'd never caught before, given that it was so subtle she could only barely see it now.

"Invisible people don't cast shadows, but they aren't completely translucent either. They cause a small disruption in the light, almost impossible to find unless you know what you're looking for," Professor Pendleton explained. "Which, obviously, I do. Still, good effort."

"Why come after me? You can clearly see the others, so why target me first?"

"Because they know they can be seen, so they are paying extra attention to their surroundings in case I try to approach. You trusted in your ability too much and let your guard down as a consequence."

Britney started to protest then realized he was right. She was so certain she was safe that she'd only focused on following, not on watching out for him. It had been a mistake, and Britney wasn't a captain because she was too stupid to learn from her failures.

"I guess I did. Can you tell me how you managed to get out of the store without us noticing at least?"

Professor Pendleton gave her a comforting smile. "Sorry, no can do. A magician never reveals his tricks."

"Well, do me one favor then."

“What’s that?”

“Make sure I’m not the only one to get eliminated this way. That would be humiliating.”

“Now that much I can certainly oblige,” Professor Pendleton assured her.

\* \* \*

Nick looked down at the professor seemingly talking to empty air from his hiding place a few floors up. Either his teacher had gone off the deep end into crazy, or Britney was now out of the running. Not surprising; she’d hardly been discreet as she punched her way through the crowd, leaving a trail of confused faces behind her. She’d likely assumed they wouldn’t notice one more body amidst the crowd pressing in around them. That false theory had made her exceptionally easy to track, at least as far as her general location. Add in that Alice was jerking her head around every few seconds, making her look insane but also rendering her nearly impossible to catch unaware, plus Will’s easy manner which indicated he had something up his sleeve, and the rest of them had been far more difficult targets.

Not that Nick was under any misimpression that Britney would be the last one tagged out. The others were doing well, but from Professor Pendleton’s disappearing act, it was obvious he’d decided to step things up a level.

That was fine with Nick; he’d been getting bored anyway.

## 153.

Dean Blaine forced himself not to look at the clock on his desk, slowly counting away the minutes. He was also unwilling to give attention to the phone, which he thought he heard ring at least twice every half hour. It would be fine. Nothing would go wrong. The proper permits had been filed, the proper response teams were on standby, and the parameters of the exam had been clearly outlined. This was Sean Pendleton he was talking about; there was a time when Blaine would have trusted that man with his life in the span of a heartbeat.

Of course, things had changed a great deal since then. Others he would have laid down his own life for were now barely willing to speak with him. Sean was far from the idealistic young man he'd been at their graduation. Blaine himself had done things he'd never expected when donning that white cape and looking out at his family, eyes brimming with pride. So much had changed since then, and that was without even counting the most unexpected curveball of them all.

\* \* \*

“Nervous?”

Blaine stopped fiddling with the clasp on his cape to look up from his chair and find Phil's smiling face beaming back down at him. His own cape was fastened perfectly, of course, the rest of his outfit crisp and stylish enough for a job interview. Phil never had to deal with things like stains or cleaning. Everything he wore was always perfect. It was just one of the hundreds of real world applications his ability came with, ones that people like Blaine and Gerard didn't have.

“That obvious?”

“We're all nervous. Sort of funny when you think about it. We had to get through four years of training, torture, and testing to make it to this moment, and now the idea of being up on stage is causing more fear than most of us felt during our final trial.”

“Public speaking is the number one fear in the world. Comes in ahead of death. No reason why we should be immune, I guess.”

“A very valid point. Would you like some help with that?” Phil



gestured to the clasp, still hanging crooked and only partially fastened. Blaine looked around the room to find the other eight graduates all had theirs on already, though he hadn't paid enough attention to know if that was because of Phil or their own skills. Either way, the time to start was drawing up fast, and Blaine would like to get at least one thing right today.

"Please."

"My pleasure." A moment passed and nothing happened. "Um, if you wouldn't mind easing back your field a bit, I can't seem to help as it is."

"Sorry," Blaine said. A brief moment of focus reigned in the aura emanating from his body until it ran across the surface of his skin. He could neutralize it entirely if he wanted - if he couldn't control it he would have been a Powered, after all - but he usually only did that when he needed healing. Blaine was accustomed to a world where he was the exception to every rule regarding Supers, and he didn't let that go without very good reason.

"There we are," Phil remarked as Blaine's clasp unhooked in the air and then reattached in the correct manner. "If you want, I can make you feel a little more relaxed too. Joshua and I have been practicing with the chemical balance in brains."

"Wouldn't that only work while I was near you?"

"No more than your cape will come undone if I walk away. Sure, your brain will start to go back to its normal levels, but it isn't an instant process. You'd at least feel good through the ceremony."

"I appreciate the offer, but I think I'll pass," Blaine replied.

"Understandable. So who all is coming to see you today?"

"My parents and my grandmother," Blaine replied. "You?"

"From outside the program? Just my mother. My dad died when I was very small."

"I'm sorry," Blaine said on reflex.

"No big deal. He was... let's just say I don't miss him. I might have been tempted to invite a few friends, if not for the family only rule."

"Yeah. It's a pain, but I see where they are coming from. We're getting our Hero names without wearing any masks. That could be dangerous down

the line.”

“No, no, I wasn’t saying I disagreed, just talking about what I’d do in a perfect world,” Phil corrected. “On the subject of names, thanks again for letting me have the one you came up with. You sure it’s okay that I use Globe?”

“Positive. It fits you better anyway. Besides, Zero has grown on me.”

“I always liked that one for you. It’s smart, and it makes it easy to underestimate what you can do,” Phil said. “There will be a lot of criminal Supers who regret making a snap judgment about the Hero named Zero.”

“I’ll do all right. I’m good, but I’m not in the same class as people like you or Joshua or Clarissa.”

“That’s where you’re dead wrong, Blaine. I admit our abilities are a bit more flashy, and they do come with more fringe benefits, but those are just perks. What’s the main purpose of Heroes?”

“To neutralize criminal Supers with as little collateral damage as possible,” Blaine recited automatically. It had been the mantra of their senior year, a credo that was a question on every exam, be it verbal or written. This was not a mission statement to be ignored: this was a binding contract each Hero swore their lives upon.

“There you go. The rest us can stop Supers, sure. But you do exactly what we’re all aspiring for. You neutralize them.”

“You can do that, too,” Blaine pointed out.

“Ah, but only if they are close enough, and stay in range, and don’t possess an ability like yours or Joshua’s that overpowers my own. I’m good, but as far as genuine stopping power, you’re better. You take away the very thing that makes them such exceptional threats. All of us are just working to get a little bit closer to what you can do naturally. You are the ideal Hero.”

“You were doing good, then you pushed it too far,” Blaine told him. In spite of his serious face, there was an undeniable hint of humor in his voice.

“Ah well. Can’t blame a guy for trying. Need help with anything else?”

“I’m set. Thanks, Phil.”

“Anytime.” With one last smile he moved on, walking over to a

stuttering Victor who was fumbling with a set of cue cards. They had to make a speech at the ceremony, each new Hero giving thanks and stating what they hoped to accomplish in the coming years. This was more troubling for some of them than others. And for one of them, it didn't appear to be a concern at all.

Blaine didn't buy that; he'd known Phil for too long. The guy hated being the center of attention. Giving a speech would be something he dreaded far more than fighting villains. He worked his way amidst the others, giving encouragement or help as needed, always focused on taking care of everyone else's concerns. It didn't mean he wasn't scared, in fact it meant the opposite: helping others was how Phil dealt with negative feelings. His natural reaction to something bad was to reach out and make the world better.

To Blaine, that made Phil the ideal Hero. Not that he would ever say such a thing out loud.

By the time it was ten minutes to eight, Tiffani had been taken out and Will seemed to have completely lost the trail. Alice still didn't know how Professor Pendleton had seen through Tiffani's illusion of a large business man blundering amidst the crowd, especially since she was sure that man hadn't been around for more than a few minutes. If she'd kept the same illusion then it would have been one thing, but Tiffani was smart. She'd obviously been changing it regularly so that no one person seemed to be tailing the professor along with his students. He'd still caught her, and with no sign of Will in the past fifteen minutes that meant it was down to her and Nick.

Whatever Professor Pendleton's power was, it definitely lent itself to rapid relocation. He'd hopped between stores multiple times, changing outfits with each movement. It was only luck, frantic searching, and keeping one eye on Nick that had allowed Alice to stay in the game this long. She couldn't figure out how he always knew when to walk off to a new area, or always seemed to see right through the professor's disguises, but she was willing to bet that knowing their instructor's ability didn't hurt. So far her money was on teleportation, even if that seemed like a long shot. There were teleporters that became Heroes, but they generally had to be exceptionally powerful to make the cut. Something about Professor Pendleton just didn't strike her that way, however at the moment she was at a loss for any better explanations.

Alice turned a corner, passing by a man in a giant cookie costume promoting a baked goods kiosk, and found herself with a sinking sensation in her gut. This was a straightaway, and even with three visible floors to search, she should be able to see at least Nick. Her eyes darted furiously about, hoping to catch a glimpse of one of them and knowing more certainly with each passing second that she wouldn't. Damn it! She'd been so close. There were only seven minutes left until the professor stopped moving. She still had fifteen minutes after that to find him; however, in a place this size, that put her odds at pretty much crap.

A gust of wind tugged at her hair and Alice fixed it on instinct. Stupid outdoor mall, whose idea was that anyway? She turned her gaze from futilely scanning the crowd up to the sky, where the night was beginning to shine through the day with the ever-so-subtle twinkling of stars. In the corner of her eye, the man in the cookie suit was chatting up a girl who was fighting the

wind to keep her skirt down at an appropriate level.

A gentle smile slid across Alice's face. She wasn't much of a football fan, but if she had been she would have known that what she was considering was commonly referred to as a "Hail Mary."

\* \* \*

Nick was the first to arrive in the gazebo where Professor Pendleton sat, his hands wrapped around a chocolate malt he'd picked up just before settling down to wait. The older man treated his student to a shake of the head as he sauntered into the finish line.

"Why am I not surprised?"

"Because you know me?" Nick tossed back. He slid onto a bench opposite of the professor. The gazebo's seating accommodations were weathered and hard. Nick was glad they wouldn't be there for very long.

"True. Used the mirrors to track me from a distance while also scanning a perimeter in case I doubled back?"

"Obviously."

"What about the times when I left the area you could visually track? I changed entire sections of the mall more than once."

"Sometimes I was able to angle the anti-theft mirror systems of the stores to expand my line of sight, sometimes I used a few techniques that are proprietary to my personal training, and once or twice I might have just gotten lucky."

"I'd find that last one hard to swallow," Professor Pendleton said, taking a loud sip of his shake. "The rest I can buy. At least you were able to get away both times I tried to grab you."

"With all due respect, I think we both know you could have done a lot better."

"Maybe I was trying to give you all a fighting chance," Professor Pendleton pointed out.

"Well, at least that worked out for one of us," Nick replied.

"Two," Will corrected, stepping into the gazebo. He checked the digital watch on his wrist. "Five minutes after the stopping point. I believe

that means I pass?”

“That you do, but I have to ask how. You haven’t been anywhere near us for some time,” Professor Pendleton said.

Will took a seat on the uncomfortable benches with them then explained. “I started hanging back after you got more aggressive in taking people out of the game. My tactic for tracking you was effective, but it did not possess a practical early warning system.”

“What, did you slip a tracker on him?”

Will nodded. “At first, yes. I used a mobile reconnaissance device I designed that was able to attach itself to him and relay his position to me. The professor ditched it at the first outfit change, unfortunately.”

“This is hardly my first rodeo,” Professor Pendleton replied.

“I’d calculated for such a possibility. Since you were kind enough to provide us the event’s location ahead of time, I spent the last few days before this breaking into their security system and designing a program specifically to locate and track Professor Pendleton’s facial features across the security cameras.” Will pulled a small device from his pocket; it looked like a car GPS unit to which he’d clearly done a tremendous amount of rewiring. “That’s why it took me a few minutes to get here. I was watching from far enough away to stay safe.”

“I have to say, I’m impressed,” Professor Pendleton admitted. “You planned, created contingencies, and used all the advanced information you had to construct as effective a strategy as you could. Well done, Mr. Murray.”

“Thank you, sir.”

Professor Pendleton finished his frozen treat and tossed it in the garbage then looked at his own watch. “Four minutes left, and to no one’s surprise, it seems Ms. Adair is nowhere in sight. We’ll wait the remaining time for the sake of formalit-”

“Freeze, you lowlife,” a uniformed officer said, hefting Professor Pendleton up by his shoulder and slamming it into one of the gazebo’s ancient wooden supports. It was sturdier than expected; the pain radiating through Professor Pendleton’s shoulder serving as excellent testament to that fact.

“I’m not sure what you think-”

“Did I tell you to talk?” The officer’s voice was a growl, anger barely contained as it twitched across his face. “Miss? Is this the man?”

From an entryway to the left a familiar form stepped out of the shadows, strolling its way across the grassy outcropping before coming to rest just outside of the gazebo’s interior.

“That’s him, officer,” Alice said, faux-distress rampant in her voice. “I’d recognize him anywhere.”

“What is going on?”

“What’s going on is that this establishment does not take kindly to men who walk around snapping pictures up women’s skirts.”

“Who WHAT?”

“Don’t bother, sicko. This young lady saw you using your camera when the women weren’t looking. Thank goodness, if not for her we might not have found you before you got away.”

Professor Pendleton looked over at Alice, who took the opportunity to pointedly take the last step into the gazebo, and twist her arm so that the face of her watch was showing. Fourteen minutes past that deadline. She’d just barely made it.

The professor continued to protest as the officer dragged him away, presumably toward some office for security footage to be reviewed. Alice sauntered past the shocked expressions of both her classmates and plopped onto the seat where their teacher had been only moments before.

“So,” she said nonchalantly. “Anyone up for dinner?”

Dean Blaine's front door slammed shut as Sean Pendleton traipsed through it, making a beeline for the dean's fridge and pulling out a cold beer. He downed it in one practiced chugging motion then pulled out two more before allowing the fridge to close.

"Four hours!" Sean said loudly, a phrase he'd repeated many times in the drive back from the mall. Blaine grabbed one of the beers from Sean's hands before it disappeared down his throat. He might need a bit of a buzz to deal with his old friend. "Four fucking hours I had to sit in that shitty little office while they went over footage from every damn angle."

"It would have been faster if we hadn't had to try and explain all your outfit changes," Blaine pointed out.

"Four hours! All because of one stupid lie that should have sorted itself as soon as they realized that I didn't even have a damned phone on me!"

"That worked against us, actually. They kept thinking you'd ditched the evidence somewhere."

Sean fell into a chair and greedily gulped half of his beer. Blaine had been called in as soon as the arrest occurred, functioning as a cross between a lawyer and a guardian as the police combed through the footage for any evidence of Sean's supposed crimes. They'd found none, of course, but somehow it had still taken several hours (four, in case that wasn't clear yet) before they were comfortable letting him go. His usual carefree disposition had melted away under the intense scrutiny and sense of time being wasted.

"And the worst part of it is that now I have to pass her."

"That's the worst part? You're a prisoner on a work detail who got hauled in for a serious crime, one he didn't actually commit, and that's the worst part?" Blaine didn't even try to keep the incredulous tone from his voice.

"Yes, it is. I just got manhandled for four hours and I don't even get to fail the girl who did it to me out of spite, because damn it if her methods didn't produce results."

"You know, the other majors have these things called 'ethics' that can be applied to the methods one uses to achieve results. I've heard legend they



exist in regular academia.”

“Which is where they belong. Subtlety is the grey area of our work, you know that as well as I do. So long as they aren’t using torture or murder or ruining lives I can’t very well fault one of my students for finding a novel way to succeed within the parameters I provide them.” Sean readjusted on the sofa and took another, smaller, drink from his beer. “Even if it would give a tremendous amount of personal satisfaction to do just that, it would set a bad precedent, and my inconvenient evening doesn’t rank higher than teaching my students properly. Will hacked the security system using the technological aspect, Alice hacked it using the human aspect. Deception is right there in the curriculum.”

“For a man forced into this role, you certainly have taken well to it,” Blaine pointed out.

Sean gave him a shrug. “What my people do is dangerous. I’ve got enough on my conscience without worrying if I under-trained some kid and sent them off to their death.”

“Speaking of things on your mind,” Blaine said, setting his beer on the table. “I notice you haven’t asked me anything about what we discussed in your cell on the day I offered you the job.”

“Did you have some new development to tell me about?”

“No.”

“Me neither. I sort of figured you would have mentioned if you did, so there wasn’t much point in pestering you about it.” Sean finished his second beer and set the empty bottle on Blaine’s coffee table.

“I know, I just... I suppose I thought you’d be more impatient.”

“Blaine, this has been my life for almost two decades. Patience wasn’t my strongpoint when I was younger, but I assure you I have grown much more familiar with the concept over my time waiting impotently in prison. I know Shelby is out there, somewhere. Unfortunately, what little trail there might have been was destroyed while I rotted in the slammer. If I go grasping about blindly, all I’m going to do is tip off the wrong people that I’m still looking. Sooner or later, something will pop up. Some clue, some piece of the puzzle we haven’t seen yet. When it does, I’ll be ready.”

“If it does, I’ll help you as much as I can,” Blaine replied.

“You got me out of my cell. I’d say that alone was more than I had any right to ask from you. Thank you, by the way. I know I was a prick when you came to make me the offer. I’m glad you didn’t let my jaded anger make me miss out on such an amazing opportunity.”

Blaine waved him off. “Cut that crap out. Once you’ve saved each other’s lives a few times, the smaller favors stop being much of a big deal. Besides, I always felt bad about having to be the one who brought you down in the first place.”

“It wasn’t your fault. I knew the risks I was taking when I made my choice. You did what we all promised to do: you stopped a criminal that regular people couldn’t.”

Silence stretched between the old friends after that, broken by a brief trip to the refrigerator for more beers. Eventually the television was turned on, and though it was stared at, it would be inaccurate to say it was watched.

“What were you trying to steal?” Blaine asked as the program flickered away to a commercial break.

“Huh?” Sean’s vocal chords leapt out ahead of his brain, registering the sounds from Blaine’s mouth but unable to piece together their meaning.

“The night I caught you. Most of what you took before was art, or mercenary theft work for money. I don’t know what you were spending it on, even if I do know the general point you were working toward. That night was different. A genetics lab didn’t really fit your target profile.”

Sean stalled, fidgeting with his beer and pretending to pay attention to the man hawking insurance on the screen. “I trust you, Blaine. I do. But this is something I don’t think you want to know. So, if you insist, I’ll tell you. But understand me first: I haven’t kept this secret for so long because it made me feel special. Sometimes knowing a single fact can change everything, and rarely for the better. So if you ask me again, be damned certain you’re ready for everything that comes with it.”

Blaine nodded his understanding and turned back to the television. Sean wouldn’t say that sort of thing without good reason, and Blaine had too much on his plate as it was. He would ask again, of that there was no doubt in his mind.

It would just have to wait for a bit longer.

“Come in, Mary,” Professor Stone said, interrupting Mary’s intended knock before it could land on the door frame. The diminutive girl lowered her hand and stepped into the office without comment. It was still strange for her, being the one whose thoughts were heard rather than the one doing the hearing. Fleetinglly she wondered if conferences of telepaths were like mime conventions, only verbal silence amidst the sound of a bustling hallway full of people.

“We don’t get together too often, mostly because of the strange feeling you’re currently experiencing,” Professor Stone said to the unasked question. “It’s humorous that we, of all people, are the least comfortable with having our minds read. One would think we’d be more open to it than anyone else.”

“Maybe it’s because we know what goes through other people’s heads that we don’t like it,” Mary pointed out.

“A valid point,” Professor Stone agreed. “Would you care for anything to drink? I can make us a pot of coffee.” A worn-out coffee maker was plugged in at the corner of her office, the red indicator light burned out to a point where one rolled the dice on getting burned every time they touched the heating plate.

“I’m more of a tea person. Thank you anyway.”

“So, would you like to tell me why you came by my office, or should we just proceed with me addressing the issue?”

“I think I’d like to articulate it,” Mary said. “That will help me keep my thoughts in order. I wanted to ask you for advice on increasing my level of precision and control with telekinesis. Training with Alex these past weeks has made me see just how great a divide rests between the two of us. Since I’ve seen your skills, I was hoping you might have some advice.”

“A perfectly reasonable question,” Professor Stone said. “One that I will likely be unable to fulfill, however, at least not to the extent you’re hoping for. The truth of the matter is that the exercises I teach in our Focus classes are what you need to be doing. They will help you improve steadily, if slowly.”

“I was worried you’d say that.”

Professor Stone sighed and shifted in her chair. “Unfortunately for Alex there is more demand for raw power than delicacy in people of our craft. You’ll likely go much further than he will, even though his precision is at a level you won’t ever reach.”

“Never?”

“I’m not saying you won’t improve; however, even among those of us with similar powers there is still room for individual variations and talents to shine. I assume the dean gave your group the ‘classification is meaningless’ speech last year?”

Mary nodded. It was one of the lectures that had stuck with her the most.

“Good. While I don’t agree with him on every point, Dean Blaine is right in that people are far too comfortable lumping us all together. Just as two men who are both good at directing might excel in different genres, two people with telepathy might have different aspects to what they can do. Take me, for example. I have an unusual gift with seeing people’s memories. With physical contact and time to concentrate, I can mentally experience almost anything that has happened to them.”

“So Alex’s specialty is his level of telekinetic control,” Mary surmised. “And mine is the amount of power I can throw around.”

“Yes and no. You are gifted in how much force you can utilize, but most of that strength comes from your years as a Powered. All that time dealing with the influx of thoughts taught you to narrow your focus, which in turn translates to a stronger telekinetic strike,” Professor Stone corrected. “I’ve done similar training myself. What I’m referring to are the subtle differences, small things we can do that we take for granted others can do as well, despite the fact that such is often not the case.”

“Um... I did once go into my friend’s subconscious.”

Professor Stone’s eyebrows raised several inches.

“Rich put us both under,” Mary said, hurriedly explaining her strange statement. “Somehow during that time I was able to enter his mind and interact with him.”

“Just him? Like mind-reading?”

“No, like his consciousness, but also a bunch of deeper things. His

insecurities, his fears, even what I suspect was his good side, all of them were manifested.”

“That is a unique ability indeed,” Professor Stone told her. “What we do as telepaths is akin to skimming the surface of a pool. We can only see, or rather hear, what is on top. Being able to delve into the depths... I’ve only ever met a few other Supers with a power like that.”

“I’ve only done it the one time. Maybe it was something about the state Rich put us in.”

“That is certainly a possibility. Our powers are comparable to chemicals. Stable on their own, but when combined there can be all manner of unanticipated reactions. Still, if I were you, I would try and test that skill some. Perhaps your power has an aspect that’s yet to be fully tapped.”

“I’ll do that,” Mary said. “After I’m done with the final match, I mean. Just trying to better my telekinesis is time consuming enough.”

“As are all things worth doing,” Professor Stone replied. “Just be sure you are focusing on bringing your abilities to their upper level, not trying to duplicate someone else’s.”

“Message received. Work on precision, but accept that I might never be able to pull off some of Alex’s stuff.”

“Exactly. My advice is to keep up your exercises and try to find ways to work around your limitation.”

“Like what?”

“Well, in our first out of class meeting I pummeled you with a barrage of rocks,” Professor Stone reminded her.

“I recall.”

“In that exchange I was able to do it because all you tried to do was move the original hunk of concrete. With your mental strength you could have easily done that and wrapped a bubble of force around yourself simultaneously.”

“I didn’t know I needed to.”

“Do you anticipate your enemies will tell you all of their objectives in a fight beforehand?”

“Not intentionally, but yes,” Mary countered. Professor Stone gave the small girl a thin smile.

“My point is that while Alex can use telekinesis to interact with people without crushing them, you can use that formidable focus of yours to simultaneously do three things he could only manage to pull off one at a time. There are a bevy of tactical options besides throwing heavy objects at people. I advise you to start exploring them.”

Nick's left shoulder came out of socket and his wrist exploded into bone fragments, barely contained by the skin wrapped around what had once been a solid bone. He stifled a cry of pain that even two weeks ago would have worked its way past his lips, using breathing techniques to focus through the initial blast of pain.

"Better," he said, his voice low and strained under the considerable effort of not passing out from shock. He'd learned that he could communicate in two-syllable bursts. Any more than that and he risked throwing up. It had not been a pleasant learning process. "Heal."

Camille obliged, laying her hand on his uninjured right arm so as not to make the process any worse than it already was. A few seconds later Nick's brain was awash in pleasure as the chemicals designed to fight back pain suddenly found no injury to contend with. He took a moment to compose himself then addressed the small girl once more.

"Again. One finger, and only a light brush."

Nick hadn't chosen to train with Camille for the reasons he'd listed, and while no one would be shocked to learn he'd had ulterior motives, they might have been served a healthy dollop of surprise if they'd known what he'd had planned. Sure, some of it was close to what he'd told them: helping Camille to become a better close-ranged brawler. His real emphasis was on giving her the chance to improve an aspect of her power he suspected she'd had very little opportunity to use. Nick was making Camille injure him over and over.

The emphasis they were focused on initially was speed. The more damage Camille could impart in the least amount of time maximized her chances of taking someone down before they had a chance to counterattack. As they'd trained, it had become apparent that the level of touch she needed to sustain was also a hindrance; it took a solid grip to impart more significant injuries. So part of their training had become teaching her to leave larger wounds with a lighter touch. She had been making serious progress, and as a side effect, Nick's, already healthy pain tolerance was growing by leaps and bounds.

Five broken ribs, a concussion, a splintered femur, and countless

bruises later, Nick finally held up his hands to signal an end for what his body could handle in a day. Although Camille could remove the actual injuries, there were certain chemical processes in the brain triggered by the barrage, adrenaline and dopamine and dozens of other things swirling together into a cocktail that would render his formidable mind useless if continued for long enough. This lesson had come after the first day when they pushed as long as they could and then Nick slept for eighteen hours, dead to the world and any attempts at waking him. Some quick lying had convinced the others he'd merely had too much to drink the night before, but from then on both of them were keenly aware that certain limits had to be observed.

"Okay," Nick said as he pulled his shirt back on. For the sake of convenience he only wore a tank-top and shorts during their fights, but soon he'd start adding layers to force Camille to work around them. "Good training session. While we've got time left, there's something I want to talk to you about."

"I'm all ears," Camille replied. Nick wasn't always the most upfront person, yet she had grown to trust that he had the best interests of the team at heart. Besides, his methods, while crazy and dangerous to him, definitely produced results.

"I had Mary stop by to end Roy and Vince's sparring a bit early. She sent Vince back to Melbrook, and she's currently walking the halls with Roy under the guise of getting an update as to where his skills are. What she's actually doing is listening to both of our thoughts, waiting for you to tell her it's okay to bring Roy in here."

"Why would she do that?"

"Because it's time to let him in on your little secret."

"Roy? Why on earth would we tell him?"

"Well, we don't have to," Nick said. "I have to say, I think he'll figure it out anyway when you start breaking his bones."

"I see. You want me to see if my powers work on him," Camille surmised. Nick cheerfully bobbed his head in agreement; it was so much easier when he got to work with someone competent.

"Your ability is incredible; right now it makes you one of the strongest people in our class. There's an unknown factor, however, one we need to test. Does your ability to impart wounds get reduced or even nullified by people



with enhanced endurance?”

“I don’t know,” Camille admitted. “I was the only Super in my high school, and I’ve never tried it on someone like Roy or Chad.”

“Yeah, that’s what I figured. But if it can, if it somehow just creates the damage in spite of their ability, then your power is more than just incredible, it’s downright insane. To completely bypass someone else’s defense like that, well, you’re one of the smart ones. I don’t have to paint a picture for you of how big a difference it can make.”

“I understand; I just don’t know that I trust Roy to keep this secret.”

“He’ll keep it from the other teams, and I feel reasonably confident I can convince him that Vince is too naïve to be trusted with it. That said, we’re getting down to crunch time. Pretty soon you’re going to have to make a choice about which you want to protect more, your secret or Vince.”

“You already know what I’ll choose,” Camille said without hesitation. He did, too. The girl was many things, but dedicated was absolutely at the top of the list.

“Then let’s make sure that when the time comes, we know exactly what you can and can’t pull off,” Nick replied.

“Fine,” Camille agreed, making sure she thought about her agreement in no uncertain terms so Mary would get the message.

It evidently worked, because some minutes later the metal door to the training room opened, revealing Mary and Roy.

“Hey, guys,” Roy greeted. “What’s going on?”

“Roy, my friend, today we are going to perform a fascinating science experiment,” Nick told him. “If you’ll be so kind as to shut the door we can get things started.” Roy obliged the request, and Camille took a moment to mentally prepare herself. Then the door was closed and there was nothing else left but action and explanation. The conclusion would be that either Roy had an exceptional defense or Camille had an ability that would make many a previously unassailable Super cringe in fear.

It was time to test some limits.

## 158.

“Thank you all for coming,” Dean Blaine said, greeting the sophomore class as they took their seats in the central auditorium, a place they hadn’t been to for some time. The dean stood at the center of the stage, an enormous screen at his back showing the cover for what most students correctly concluded was a slide presentation. Each of the professors sat in a metal folding chair, all six lined up behind the dean and below the screen. The looks on their faces ranged from bored all the way to disinterested. Given that the month had just turned to May, the sophomores would have far rather been training than attending some presentation, so they looked far from enthralled as well.

“I called you all here because, as you know, the end of the year is almost upon us,” Dean Blaine continued. “As you might also recall, that comes with more than just the commencement of our year-end exams. The upper classmen all work together to put on something of a carnival event for the freshmen, a congratulatory celebration to put them at ease before their trials.” He left out how chaotic last year’s had been thanks to Michael Clark hijacking a microphone and outing the Melbrook residents. No need to reopen old wounds.

Dean Blaine started to speak again; however, he was interrupted by the high-pitched chirping of a cell phone. He would have admonished the owner for not turning their phone on silent had he not been the owner. He had turned it on silent, however there were certain numbers programmed in that bypassed such restrictions, numbers so important that they were intended to never be ignored. This time he pressed a button to mute the chirping anyway, reasoning that he had a short speech and could return the call as soon as it was over.

“Sorry about that. Now, while the juniors and seniors do the bulk of the work, the sophomores will still be participating in some committees to help out, utilizing their unique skills to-”

The high-pitched tone echoed through the room again and Dean Blaine had to bite back a curse that tried to sneak its way across his tongue. He smashed the button to silence it again, this time far less delicately, and turned back to his audience.

“Apologies once more. Today we’re here to allow you all to

volunteer-”

More ringing, this time accompanied by a wave of curious whispers that passed through his students. It seemed this was a battle he was going to lose. Rather than continue with the vaudeville routine, Dean Blaine pulled the phone from his holster and turned his back on the audience of students.

“What is so damned important?” Dean Blaine snapped into the small black device. He stood silently as he listened, the voice on the other line too quiet to even be heard, let alone discerned. Amber was getting curious enough to try and amplify the waves, but before she had a chance, the dean lowered his phone and clicked a button to end the call. When he turned back around she found herself very glad she hadn’t done anything of the sort. His usual good cheer and patience were gone, wiped from his face, leaving the haggard look of a man who has seen too much blood in his life and has a sense he was about to look upon more.

“Everyone stay here,” Dean Blaine informed them. “Your professors and I have something to attend to. The other HCP students will be coming in to join you shortly. Please sit quietly until we return.” He motioned to the people seated behind him, all of whom rose from their seats immediately and followed him out of the room. The thick door shut with a clang, followed immediately by the sound of a large lock sliding into place.

“Something tells me this isn’t all because a snow cone machine got delivered too early,” Nick muttered.

“Gee, you think?” Stella said, not bothering to keep her tone quiet. “Obviously some big shit is going down. I think they just locked our asses in here.”

“If they locked the door it is for our safety,” Chad said calmly. “There are protocols for certain events designed to maintain the safety of the student body. This structure is highly fortified, even against natural disasters such as earthquakes.”

“Wait, so something that was important enough to have all four classes gather in here would be a pretty big deal, right?” Jill asked.

“Not guaranteed, but it would be very likely,” Chad agreed. “Why?”

“Because I’m going to see if that thing gets cable,” Jill replied, pointing at the screen that still showed the title page for the slideshow it seemed unlikely the dean would be presenting anytime soon. She closed her

eyes and the screen flickered, switching through various input functions before a local television station airing a daytime soap opera filled the screen. The channels began flipping by as Jill moved through them, finally settling on a national news network.

The moment the channel came on it was clear this was not regularly scheduled programming. The newswoman's make-up was smudged, as if she'd been throwing it on in the car ride over instead of being professionally groomed by a trained artist. Uniformed officers milled about behind her, occasionally shooting the girl and her crew angry looks, making it clear they despised even their presence at such a scene. Her lips moved wordless for a few seconds before Jill turned the sound up, and when they heard what she was saying many of the students immediately wished she hadn't.

"-no casualties being reported so far. For those of you just tuning in, again the breaking story today is the jailbreak that happened at the Sanderson Maximum Security Prison for Supers. One incarcerated man, being identified as the former Hero Relentless Steel, was pulled free by a group of three Supers intent on his extrication."

Eyes widened and nerves tightened at this announcement. Although the media was not allowed to release the names of even disgraced Heroes, it was common knowledge that the man once called Relentless Steel had the ability to transform into a living robot, a power most had observed was strikingly similar to another man they all knew, one who had also been stuck in prison after kidnapping a student last year.

The reporter blurred for a moment, the signal from her location clearly not stable. They could all see waves in the background, which made sense. Sanderson was an island penitentiary; she was probably reporting from the shoreline. The image became crisp again moments later, and she continued her report.

"Normally this would be the most shocking turn of event, given Sanderson's reputation for being inescapable; however, we've gotten confirmation that not only were two of the three criminals former Heroes Raze and Mood Swing, both already with warrants out for their arrest, but it seems they were being led by another former Hero, this one believed to be deceased."

Vince felt a very heavy sinking sensation somewhere in his gut.

"We've just received security footage taken of their escape," the

reporter said, her face vanishing as four people floating on what appeared to be a giant rock filled the screen. Two of them were familiar: despite the costume and mask, Persephone's figure would have stood out clearly in a burlap sack. George didn't have any concealment as he kneeled on the floating piece of earth, only a threadbare prison jumpsuit. The other two men wore Hero masks as well. Even without the facial coverings, they would have still been unrecognizable to most of the students. Most, but not all.

"As you can clearly see, the man known as Globe is leading their attack and coordinating their escape. Inquiries to his former teammates who reported his death have so far been met only with silence."

The screen zoomed in on the man; he was saying something to George that couldn't be recorded from the camera's distance. He wore a long red coat, tattered with time but still highly recognizable. One student would have known it anywhere, just as he would have known the line of the man's jaw or the way he stood when he was trying to protect someone.

"Father," Vince whispered, his voice barely audible even to himself. It might have traveled further than he realized, because a mass of eyes turned to stare at him. Vince didn't notice, couldn't even see them. All he could see was the face on the screen, all he could hear was the strange ringing that filled his ears. He did notice a curious orange tint that seemed to be coloring the edge of his peripheral vision, but he couldn't have told you what it was. Vince didn't see anything other than the man on the screen, his face superimposed over a half-decade old memory of a burning boxcar that Vince had looked down on from a cliff. He could hear his own screams from that day, or maybe someone else was screaming. Maybe a lot of people were; it was so hard to tell.

His line of sight to the screen was cut short as a pair of fleetingly familiar eyes appeared in front of his own. That was the last image Vince got before his body fell limply to the floor.

## 159.

“Put him down!”

“What the fuck did you do?”

“I stopped us all from being burned to death. Some of us aren’t fucking flame retardant!”

“Roy, put him down right now.”

“I will when he lets Vince go.”

“I don’t think that’s a good idea. Rich is right; he was having a mental breakdown. He didn’t even seem to notice the fire.”

“Then what do you suggest? He’s got to deal with it when he wakes up, and he can’t stay out forever.”

“Can you still craft fake situations after you’ve already put someone under?”

“Sure, I just have to look in their eyes again. Why?”

“I’ve got an idea.”

\* \* \*

Vince’s eyes snapped open as he jerked upright in his bed. He could still hear the voices bickering somewhere in the depths of his mind, but he couldn’t really remember what they were saying. His brain felt groggy, like he’d barely slept a wink last night. It wasn’t really surprising; that had been one hell of a detailed dream. He swung his feet out of the covers and hopped onto the floor, officially beginning his day.

The sunlight streamed through his window. Outside the neighborhood was just waking up. It was a quiet little cul-de-sac, mostly full of three bedroom houses cut from the same set of design templates. The exception was the Adairs’ house down the street, which had been custom-made and easily dwarfed the rest of the abodes surrounding it. Vince never understood why Charles Adair wanted to live in a neighborhood like theirs when he clearly belonged in a higher income area. His mind slid over the question, unable to even conceive of it as something he should dwell on.

The clock was blinking seven thirty, which meant he'd managed to oversleep again. Hurriedly brushing his teeth and throwing on clean clothes, Vince paused briefly to shave in the mirror and style his light-chocolate-colored hair. It was so dull and ordinary, no wonder he'd given himself a mane of silver in his dream.

A ritualistic hunt for his sneakers, the modern manifestation of killing a buffalo, wasted five more minutes, so by the time he stumbled down the stairs into the kitchen, Vince was beginning to be on the cusp of truly being late. Coach was going to be pissed.

"Morning, champ," his father greeted him, currently poised at the stove whipping a spatula through some recently cracked eggs. There was also the distinctive sizzle of bacon and the unmistakable scent of coffee filling the air. Father took all his meals seriously; he believed that the fall of modern society would come from lack of home-cooking rather than gangs or violence. The red apron that was draped across his torso was worn and threadbare, not to mention a bit frilly around the edges. Vince had told him for years he needed a new one, but it had been a gift from Vince's mother before she passed, so Father was loathe to give it up.

As he took a seat at the table Vince's head throbbed, images from his dream rising unbidden from the depths of his subconscious. His father, faking his own death, only to emerge years later as some legendary criminal. It was so ridiculous, yet for some reason Vince felt a pang of queasiness in his stomach.

"How you feeling today? Any new symptoms?"

"Symptoms?" Vince said uncertainly.

"Well, there's the memory loss they warned us about," his father said with a sigh. "You got cracked on the head during practice yesterday. Minor concussion, and given that you were taken down by the Daniels boy I'd say that was getting off light."

"Right... right," Vince said, new memories rising up to take the place of the ones from his dream. "Roy tackled me when I intercepted that pass, and I knocked my head on the ground."

"Whew, glad that mind of yours is still working. We Reynolds men can't afford to lose too many brain cells." His father gave him a wink at the joke, and then slid a steaming pile of fluffy eggs onto a pair of plates. Bacon joined the former future fowls, followed by a cup of coffee on the side. He sat

the plate in front of his son then sat across from Vince with his own.

The Reynolds men... but only Vince's last name was Reynolds, wasn't it?

A throb came from his temple and Vince shook his head. Whatever thought had been perched at the edge of his mind was lost in the impromptu head-banging, so Vince turned his attention to breakfast. The food was crisp and delicious, as always. For a police officer, Vince's dad had a surprising amount of hidden culinary talent.

"You'd better hurry," his father said. "Nick will be here any minute, and I hate the way that boy drives when he's running late."

"Nick?"

"Nick Campbell. Son, are you sure you're okay? You've known Nick since you were kids, and he's been driving you to school since he got his license. If you forgot him then maybe we need to go back to the doctor for more tests."

"Right, no, I know Nick," Vince said, his brain catching up to his dad's description. "I just forgot he was picking me up. I'm fine: a little slow on the uptake, but fine." He was, too. The concern and care in his father's voice had banished the uneasy feeling that had been lingering in his gut. It was a stupid dream. His father was the best man he knew, whatever reason his subconscious had possessed for casting him in the role of villain was irrelevant. It wasn't real.

Vince gobbled his food hurriedly while his father slowly turned his own attention back to breakfast. The man kept a wary eye on his boy, checking for any further symptoms that indicated a serious issue.

"So, you nervous about your upcoming finals?" It was a blatant topic change, and Vince accepted the spirit with which it was intended.

"I guess I am. More than I realized, anyway. I had a stress dream last night that was unbelievable."

"Oh yeah? What happened in it?"

"Well, the first part is the weirdest. It was set in a world where people actually had super powers."



Nick's ancient VW Bug protested his attempts to turn maneuvering simple neighborhood streets into a smash 'em up video game, but the grinding cries from its engine went unheeded as its owner jerked the wheel and sent his passenger bouncing against a door that miraculously held closed.

"Fucking shitty drivers," Nick mumbled, revving past the blue Ford that had committed the unforgivable sin of slowing down to take a right turn. The Bug gave out a weary sputter and lurched into a higher gear, sounding as if the effort had taken several years off its already dwindling lifespan.

"Are you sure you should be going so fast on these streets?"

"Hey, I don't want to hear shit from you. I pull up and honk and it takes you five minutes to get to the car. You know damn well I run on a very efficient schedule with no wasted time. That five minutes has got to come out of something else now, but we both know morning practice shouldn't be that spot. I doubt twenty laps for every minute late are good for someone recovering from a head injury."

"Right... maybe I shouldn't be practicing in the first place," Vince pointed out.

"Of course you're not practicing. Jesus, even your coach isn't that big of a dickbag. He just requires everyone be present, even the injured. Thinks even the act of watching your team helps you get better at assessing strengths and weaknesses," Nick reminded him. "I'd call bullshit, but the man produces results."

"I guess so." Vince was having trouble keeping the memories straight in his head. He knew their undefeated football team had won a championship that year, he could even remember holding the trophy with the rest of the team. What he couldn't remember were the small details, like what plays they'd used to pull off their come-from-behind victory. Shouldn't he remember something like that? Meanwhile his dream memories kept popping up, making him wonder why Nick wasn't wearing his sunglasses. He'd opened his mouth to ask several times, only to realize how insane that question was since the real Nick only wore them when he was driving and it was bright out.

The Bug gave one final burst of speed as Nick maneuvered it into the

east Lander parking lot. It was a sizable university, and much of the student body lived off campus, so there were parking facilities set up all over the place. With the approach of finals, many were choosing to use their daytime hours holed up at home and buried in books, which meant Nick was able to score a spot near the front of the lot, drastically cutting down on their walking time.

“All right, Cinderella, this is as far as the carriage takes you,” Nick said, snapping up his backpack from the rear seat and killing the sputtering engine. “I’ll meet you at the cafeteria in Hoffman Hall for lunch at eleven. Try not to go all mentally-deficient boy and get lost before then.”

“I’ll do my best,” Vince said, a little more honesty in the statement than he would have preferred. He was having real issues with keeping everything straight, so it was seeming increasingly possible that he could get mixed up and go to the wrong place. At least his next destination had been laid out for him. The Lander Stadium loomed before them, just a few minutes’ walk from the east parking lot. He needed to get to practice. Hopefully a little time to just sit and watch people play would give him a chance to clear his head.

\* \* \*

“How’s it going?”

“How the hell should I know? All I do is provide the framework, their mind usually fills in the rest. I did what she told me, but if I had to guess it’s probably not much fun to be him right now.”

“Why not?”

“I usually put them in a place without any doubt. The world they see is the real one. They just accept it since the assurance is coming from their own brain. She made me keep some doubts in there this time, so I’d guess it feels a little bit like he’s losing his mind.”

“Damn. Is Mary almost ready to go in?”

“Yeah, we’re about to start.”

“Good. Fucking hell, I really hope this works.”

\* \* \*

“Nice hit, Daniels!” Coach George’s voice boomed across the field;

somehow the barely-above-average-height man produced enough sound in his body to fill an entire stadium with his usually critical shouts. “But keep that shit confined to the big guys. I can’t have you cripple my whole fucking team before next season.”

“You got it, Coach,” Roy called back, helping Thomas Castillo back onto to his feet. The tan boy accepted the gesture wordlessly; holding grudges for being tackled in football made as much as sense as getting angry at a waiter for bringing you the food you ordered. Both lined up on opposing sides; in this scrimmage, Thomas was acting as quarterback for the jersey wearing team, who were currently on offense. It seemed a little unfair that Coach George would put Chad, their first string quarterback, on the same team as Roy, who led their league in sacks, but he was a man who believed you forged a better blade by putting it in a hotter fire. He was demanding, unpleasant, and at least halfway insane. People fought like drunken weasels for the chance to play under him.

“How you feeling, Vince?”

Vince turned his head away from the scrimmage to see Hershel Daniels, the towel resource manager, take a seat next to him. The world went tilty for a moment as everything seemed to lose cohesion. How could Hershel be here when Roy was on the field? Because they were fraternal twins, not two people sharing the same body. Vince was slowly getting a handle on re-imposing reality over the dream delusions that dogged him.

“I’m better than I was yesterday,” he replied after his brain stabilized. “The doctors don’t think it was anything too bad. Just got my bell rung.”

“Glad to hear it. Roy felt awful last night. He has a hard time gauging his strength on the field.”

“Tell him I’m fine. And remind him I intercepted the ball, so he was supposed to tackle me. That’s why we practice.”

“I’ll try and get through to him.” Hershel turned his own attention to the field. “Looks like we’ll have another strong team next year.”

No, we won’t. We’re fighting just to stay afloat. Nick says if we don’t decimate in the final match we could lose people from the program. They need me. No, they don’t, because they aren’t real.

“Sure does,” Vince agreed, flashing his friend a large smile. “Hey, this may sound like a weird question, but I have history after this, right?”



Vince did indeed have History of War next, though he wondered what he'd been thinking scheduling a class so far across campus with so little time to make the trip. He burst into the lecture hall, thankful the professor still seemed to be arranging notes on his desk. Professor Fletcher was an older teacher, and as such he'd taken tenure and said goodbye to much need for impressing people or punctuality. He was still a dynamite educator, passionately articulating stories of the ancient Greeks' battle strategies, or dealing with more modern examples all the way through World War Two. He knew the little pieces of history that made it interesting, breathing life into what most students only ever saw as dead people and old stories.

A quick scan of the room revealed a familiar face, and Vince plopped into a seat next to Camille and pulled out his notebook.

"Made it by the skin of my teeth this time," he whispered, feeling relieved that he didn't have to do the walk of shame down the hall's steps as Professor Fletcher lectured on. The man didn't stop once he started, and it somehow made the awkwardness of coming in late even worse.

Camille didn't immediately respond; instead she glanced at him, turned bright red, and found something very interesting on her paper to stare at. That was weird; why wasn't she talking to him? The class hadn't started yet, and Professor Fletcher wasn't the kind of man who cared about people chatting before he began speaking.

Then Vince realized his error. He and Camille were friends in the dream, but in reality they only knew each other in a cursory fashion. They had several of the same friends, but rarely spoke to each other besides rapid greetings. Their social circles were like a Venn diagram, intersecting only in a relatively small portion. He'd always got the feeling she didn't care much for him, actually, but he had no idea what he'd done to offend her. In fact, he didn't even sit here in this class; usually he took notes up near Will.

A quick turn over his shoulder revealed his friend looking down at him, confusion evident on his face. Vince started to move, but of course Professor Fletcher chose that moment to begin his lecture. Easing back into his seat, Vince looked over at the girl once more, catching her eyes glancing at him from the supposedly safe corners of their sockets. They darted back to the paper immediately, and he didn't suspect they'd be journeying in his

direction again anytime soon.

As Professor Fletcher droned on, Vince found himself struck by the curiousness of Camille's role in his dream. He'd cast the girl he barely knew as someone very close to him, one of his best friends. That seemed odd, given how little they'd ever interacted in the real world. Maybe he'd noticed her more than he realized. Or maybe it was just that his dream had been composed of such a large cast that he'd had to pull from all over to fill every role. He'd cast his father as the villain, for goodness sake. There was no sense in reading too far into it.

Class wrapped up fifty minutes later, the professor's dismissal followed by a flurry of activity as students shoved papers and pens into their backpacks. Vince joined in, wondering how he was going to explain his odd gaffe to Will. If he leaned on the head injury explanation too many more times they were going to send him back to the hospital for additional testing. That would worry his father, plus he was reasonably sure it was a waste of time. Maybe he could tell Will that he'd been hitting on Camille. Nah, Will was too smart for that one.

Vince was so absorbed in thought that he almost didn't hear the soft mutter that came from Camille's lips. Looking over, he saw she was red again, and her eyes were facing straight forward. She wore a look of determination, and she hadn't made any moves to put her pens or notebook away.

"I'm sorry, I don't think I caught that," Vince said politely.

"Eleven years," Camille repeated, this time just barely loud enough to actually be heard. "Eleven years, and when you finally talk to me, all you say to me is some comment about almost being late to class." She grabbed her supplies and jammed them into her bag; at least two pens and a sheet of paper were destroyed in the bout of furious packing. She stood up from her seat, though with her height it didn't make much of a difference, and finally looked Vince in the eye.

"You're an ass," Camille spat, turning on her heels and rushing out before Vince could conjure any sort of reply. He merely stared, dumbfounded, as the small girl dashed up the stairs and ran out of the lecture hall.

"I see that legendary Reynolds charm is still as potent as always," Will said from behind Vince, snapping him out of his stupor.

"I have no idea what I did to deserve that," he said. He didn't, either;

neither in the dream world or this one could he remember an action that warranted such venom.

“Women, eh? Can’t live with them, and I don’t know how to cook.” Will smacked his friend on the shoulder and gave him a smile. “Come on, that was funny.”

“Huh? Uh, yeah, I guess it was.” Vince finally shook off the strange feeling he’d had since Camille’s tongue-lashing, scooping his own bag off the floor and standing from his chair.

“It still doesn’t explain why you sat there in the first place,” Will pointed out as the two began to ascend the stairs. “I know it’s been long enough since you and Sasha broke up to put yourself back out there, but maybe you should try someone a little more affable. And who doesn’t apparently hate your guts.”

“I wasn’t... yeah, maybe you’re right,” Vince agreed. Will had given him an out from admitting he didn’t mean to sit there in the first place. Vince might not be able to lie worth a damn, but he could certainly let someone else fill in the blanks for themselves. He was pretty sure that was morally tolerable, but admittedly not preferred. “I hope my next class goes quick. I cannot wait for this day to be over.”

“The gods listen for that sort of statement,” Will informed him. “Which means you’re in for a hell of a long day.”

Vince made it to lunch without much more difficulty. His sense of a split world was reduced by the fact that his next class was geometry, and he was awful at math no matter which reality he was currently in. He met up with Nick at Hoffman, only to discover this was a ritual involving more than just Vince and his chauffeur. It seemed all the students from Melbrook Avenue grabbed food together when their schedule allowed. Roy and Hershel were the first to arrive after Vince and Nick, followed not long after by Alice. She dropped her purse and backpack next to Nick, then immediately picked up where they'd left off in their most recent fight. It had always struck Vince as strange that people who squabbled so constantly would also continually choose one another's company. Mary was the last to arrive, grabbing a free seat to Vince's left.

"How you feeling today?"

"A little tired of everyone asking me that, honestly," Vince said. He began backpedaling as soon as the words were out of his mouth. "I'm sorry; I know you're all concerned, I've just been having some slight concentration issues."

"I know how it goes," Mary assured him. "I've gotten my share of head bonks from messing up while climbing trees."

Why hadn't she just stopped herself telekinetically? Because that was the dream, duh. Besides, even dream Mary had trouble grabbing humans with her ability; she was so powerful it was too easy to crush them.

"So how long does this last?"

"In my experience, the head fuzziness usually goes away after a day or so. The part I had trouble shaking was the dreams."

A ketchup-covered chicken tender froze halfway to Vince's mouth, his hunger forgotten as a single word of Mary's sentence stole precedence from all the others.

"Dreams?"

"Oh yeah. I don't know if it was just me or what, but man, I had some doozies after a few of my falls. Complex, detailed, somehow almost as real as my own life. In fact, after some of the really intense ones I even had trouble



sorting out what was real and what had been part of my unconscious theatre,” Mary explained, her own appetite unhindered by the conversation.

A warm sense of relief washed over Vince and the interrupted chicken tender finally met its inevitable fate. He wasn’t going crazy. This was all just part of dealing with a head injury.

“I see. I think I had one of those last night,” Vince eventually replied. “Did the sense of not quite keeping things straight go away with the general disorientation?”

“Actually, no,” Mary told him. “I had to be a bit more proactive with those.”

“By all means, please elaborate.”

“It’s hard to explain,” she said, setting down the veggie wrap that was already halfway consumed. “I guess I’d say that talking about it helped me a lot. For whatever reason, things were sticky in my brain, and talking to the people involved usually helped me sort things out. Especially in the cases where I couldn’t understand why I’d cast someone in seemingly strange roles. Like when I had one where I was a princess in a fairytale land, I got kidnapped by an evil dragon who talked and kind of looked a lot like Hershel. Not a usual role for the boy I secretly had a crush on.”

“Agreed, I have no idea what that means.”

“Me neither,” Mary said with a shrug. “But when I told him about it, we wound up talking for a long time, and in the course of that I was able to sort out which Hershel was the real one.” She paused to look over at her boyfriend, busily scribbling in a notebook while cramming a hamburger down his gullet. The two had been sitting apart so he could cram for his big Biology final this week. Hershel was the kind of guy who couldn’t focus if his girlfriend even sat down beside him. Mary thought it was endearing.

“Huh. I’ll keep that in mind,” Vince said.

“So what did you dream about?”

“Oh... um, well, we were all people with super powers, only we weren’t supposed to be, sort of, and we were going to college to try and become super heroes,” Vince explained, the tips of his ears turning red as he realized how crazy that sounded.

“Sounds a lot like our actual life, just if you blended it together with

comic books,” Mary pointed out.

“There were a few key differences,” Vince said. “For one thing, I cast my dad as the villain.”

“Ohhhh. So that’s the part that’s bothering you.”

“Why do you say that?”

“Vince, you adore your father. No one here looks up to a parent more than you. I can see how your subconscious sticking him in a role like that would bother you a lot.”

Vince started to protest; he’d gotten over it this morning. Hadn’t he? The more he turned Mary’s words over in his head, the more he realized that the general sense of anxiety he was feeling seemed to be inevitably tethered back to those moments just before he woke up. Everyone watching as the father he’d thought he lost helped the man who’d kidnapped Mary escape from jail.

“What was my power?”

“Huh?”

“I was trying to blatantly change the subject since you seemed uncomfortable. What was my power?” Mary repeated.

“You were telepathic and telekinetic,” Vince informed her. “Alice could fly, Nick had control over luck, Roy and Hershel were weirdly the same person, and I absorbed energy.”

“Wow, you did not half-ass this dream.”

“That’s barely even scratching the surface,” Vince told her. “Most of the people from the football team were there, along with a good portion of the cheerleaders, not to mention Will, Jill, Stella, and even that quiet girl who hangs around with Violet. Camille. That last mix-up got me in trouble earlier today.”

Mary’s look of gentle interest turned into one of puzzlement. “How so?”

“In the dream we were friends, but apparently in this world she really kind of hates me.”

“That’s... very peculiar,” Mary said; however, Vince’s attention had

drifted rapidly away from her. Instead he was focused on the place in the dining hall where trays were returned and trash was thrown away. Or rather, what he saw there.

It was only a glimpse, but he knew his eyes hadn't deceived him. He was up from the table in seconds, damn near sprinting across the room. It took all the self-control he had not to go vaulting over tables. Vince spun around the corner to find the area empty, save for a stack of red plastic trays. Slowly sanity restored itself and he realized he must have looked like an idiot dashing through the dining hall like that. He couldn't help it. A girl with a familiar figure and a mane of tangled dark curls had gone in here, he was sure of it, and for whatever reason he'd needed to see her. To talk with her. To touch her. She was gone; maybe she hadn't even been here to begin with. Just another phantom from his concussion.

Vince turned and headed back to do some explaining at his table. It seemed that was the theme of his day.

## 163.

Several more classes, an evening study session, more than a few gaffes, and one death-courting car ride found Vince finally back at home as the sun began to dip below the horizon. The lights from the kitchen twinkled in dusk's fading glow, illuminating his father scurrying about and getting dinner ready. He would have gotten off shift about an hour ago; during non-finals time Vince would have beaten him home. He knew that to be true, yet he also knew that his father had seemingly died in a fire when Vince was thirteen. It didn't matter that one was a dream anymore. Something in it still felt real, which meant Vince needed to deal with it.

He dropped his backpack in the front hallway then headed into the kitchen where he was greeted with a symphony of scents, all combining to form the unmistakable odor of baking lasagna.

"Hey, kid," his father greeted. "Just got it in the oven a few minutes ago, so you've got some time before dinner. How's the head?"

"Tired," Vince replied, taking a seat at the table. "And a little confused, to be honest."

"Anything serious?" His father stopped fiddling with the salad bowl he'd been filling full of greens to face his son.

"Not in a medical way, no. I've just been having this weird experience where I mix up things from my dream last night."

"The one where everyone had superpowers?"

"That's the one."

"Huh, it would seem like that would be pretty easy to separate from reality."

"I've been getting better at it through the day," Vince replied. "But it's more what happened in it that's bothering me. Or, I mean, the way certain people acted in it. Including you."

His father set down his tongs and went to the fridge, pulling out a pair of sodas. He placed one in front of Vince and took the other to his seat, directly across from his son.

"Sounds like you need to talk."

“I do, but it feels crazy trying to sort out how I feel about things that didn’t happen.”

“They happened to you. Even if it wasn’t real, you still have memory of those events,” his father pointed out. “So let’s deal with them. You can talk to me about anything.”

Vince hesitated, then the temptation grew too strong and the words started tumbling out. He didn’t tell his father everything - the dream had been far too expansive and detailed for that - but he made sure to hit the high points involving the faked death, the kidnapping attempt, the accusations about Globe, and the shock of discovering it was all true. He talked halfway through the lasagna’s cooking time, which he could tell by the slow-moving timer perched atop the stove. When Vince was finally done, his father took a long sip from his soda before responding.

“Man, I sound like kind of a jerk in your dream.”

Vince snorted a laugh, almost spitting some of his own drink in the process.

“So that’s what’s bothering you? That your subconscious would put me in the role of villain?”

“Yeah. I don’t know why it would do that.”

“Well, it didn’t. Not really.” Vince tilted his head in confusion, spurring his father to continue on. “Think about it: in your dream all your actual experiences with me sound a lot like that ones we really have. We talked, shared openly, and had a darn healthy father-son relationship, which I feel like is a good summary of how things really are.”

“I completely agree,” Vince said without hesitation.

“Now, as to all that villain stuff, it seems to me every bit of that came to you second-hand. People told you about the things I’d done, people told you Globe was a bad person, but you never actually saw me do anything particularly evil.”

“I saw you fake your own death,” Vince pointed out. “Plus break the man who kidnapped Mary out of jail.”

“Okay, I’ll give you those are valid points. Doesn’t mean there aren’t possible explanations behind them. If I were a betting man, I’d say your dream was trying to teach you that sometimes you have to make a choice

about what you're going to believe. You can trust what others tell you, or go with the things that you know to be true. Maybe the solution for the dream version of you is to still accept my actions for the crimes they are, but trust that the man committing them is still the same father who took you in from the streets. You know some of what he's done, but none of the why behind those actions."

"Doesn't sound easy."

"Doesn't sound like your dream-self does anything the easy way, which matches up pretty well to the real one," his father said, reaching across the table and squeezing Vince's hand. "All I can tell you is how I interpret it. If that doesn't work then keep turning it over in your brain until you find a way to look at it that feels right."

"Thanks. I know the whole thing makes no sense, but I feel strangely better." It was true; the continuous weight in his stomach seemed to have been alleviated. In fact, with every passing second, Vince was having more and more trouble remembering what had made him so upset.

"Any time. You know that. Now how about you go grab a shower before dinner? I think a hot water submersion will clear away the last of those mental cobwebs. Also, not to be rude, but I can still smell the fear-sweat on you from riding home with Nick."

"Sure," Vince said, heading for the stairs and taking them two at a time.

His father got up and began messing with the salad again, pausing to put a pot of coffee on the burner. He did love a good cup of mud after a heavy Italian meal. The salad was finished by the time he heard a light knock on the front door. Not bothering to take off his apron, he walked to the door and pulled it open, revealing a somewhat awkward Mary.

"Good evening, Mary. What brings you to our home this evening?"

"I just wanted to check on Vince. He still seemed a bit out of sorts at lunch today."

"Aren't you a good friend? He's doing fine, but since you're here I insist you come have dinner with us." Vince's father hustled her into the kitchen and pulled out a seat for her at the table. "Would you care for anything to drink?"

“Tea would be great, if you have it,” she replied distractedly, her focus busy as she looked around the house. It was like it was the first time she’d ever been here.

“If memory serves we should have some of your favorite, lavender tea,” he said, digging about in the cabinet. Discovering the bags, he laid them on the counter and set a teapot on the stove to boil. Before sitting down he poured himself a cup of coffee, then rejoined Mary at the table. The girl he found waiting for him was in a very different mood from the one he’d brought through the door.

“How did you know that?” Mary asked, her usually cheerful face suddenly quite severe.

“My dear girl, you’ve lived four houses down since you were a child. I think I can at least remember your favorite tea.”

“Except that until a few months ago I drank oolong, and I doubt Vince ever knew that. I’m positive I didn’t tell him that I made the switch to lavender.”

“Well, my boy might not be very perceptive on the details; however, I make it a point to be,” he replied, sipping a bit of his coffee.

“That’s not the point. The point is that Vince didn’t know that bit of information, so there’s no way some assembled memory of his father could access it.” Mary’s hands were growing numb from gripping the table, a rising sense of uneasiness making the temptation to panic increasingly stronger.

“Oh, come now, Mary, I wouldn’t be a very good father if I didn’t do a little research on the people my son spent all his time with.” Globe set the mug of still-steaming coffee on the table and treated her to another small smile. “And as to the question you’re trying so hard not to ask, don’t tell me it never occurred to you that you’re not the only one with the power to travel into someone’s dreams?”

Mary stayed calm. She'd been working hard on keeping a cool head during stressful situations so as not to let her level of precision slip. So she very calmly unleashed a blast of telekinetic force designed to send the man across the table through at least three houses before he slowed down. Mary was somewhat less calm when not even a slight shove seemed to manifest.

"No super powers in this world," Vince's father helpfully reminded her. "Given the surprise on your face I'm guessing you tried something pretty ostentatious. It's built right into the framework. I'm afraid no ability other than the ones that allow you to enter and exit will function. Now, I'll go see about your tea." He stood up and walked over to the teapot, which Mary had failed to notice whistling. "Of course, you could still yell for Vince and tell him everything; however, I'd appreciate it if you didn't. This experience will help him greatly in dealing with my recent activities. I'd hate to see it ruined."

Mary stayed quiet as he set the cup of hot water and the bags down on a small plate, along with a small spoon, a packet of sugar, and a bottle of honey. He slid them across, making sure to keep his distance non-threatening. The cup was steaming freely as Mary looked into its clear depths.

"You don't really expect me to drink something you handed me, do you?"

"No, I suppose I don't, but it seemed impolite not to at least offer."

"I could still attack you, even without my powers."

"You certainly could, however seeing as neither of us is here physically, I'm not sure what you would be aiming to accomplish." He took a swig of his coffee before continuing. "I am glad for this opportunity, at least. I've wanted to apologize for the incident with George and Persephone since it happened."

"Sure, and next you're going to tell me how this whole thing is a set up and you're not really to blame for any of it."

"No, I won't be telling you that," he said, the polite happiness on his face suddenly overshadowed by some ancient ache from deep within. "Are things more complex than you realize? Almost always. But I will not claim false innocence. Make no mistake, Mary, the death of Intra, your kidnapping,



and much of what is to come, it is all my fault.”

She hadn’t quite expected that. The man was so open and upfront, it was like, well, it was like talking to Vince. Absentmindedly she began dunking the teabag in her cup. “How are you here, anyway? I just saw you getting chased on the news.”

“What you saw was footage, footage that had been reviewed, censored, and reviewed again before it was ever cleared to broadcast to the general public. We’ve been holed up for over two hours. The limits on what media can report regarding Heroes cause some pretty glaring gaps in efficiency. We’ve only got a little bit before Vince returns; I’d suggest asking me things you actually care about.”

“Fine. Why did you break out George? And why did he try to kidnap me in the first place?”

“For the first, it is because George is a friend who was only following orders. I won’t let anyone suffer on my account when I can help it. As to the second, I’m afraid I won’t answer that yet. Suffice it to say that there was a preferred Plan A and a more realistic Plan B. We are now well within the depths of B.” The coffee was finished off in a single final gulp and he rose to get more. While up he stopped to check on the lasagna. “I’m guessing you’re the one who will tell them when to wake Vince up?”

“I’ll go back to my own brain and give the signal. Rich left me still able to communicate,” Mary confirmed.

“Quite a useful power that boy has. Don’t suppose I could convince you to wait until after dinner? Vince and I haven’t gotten to spend any time together for a long while.”

“That happens when you fake your own death to get away from him.”

“Given what you know about me, that should be the easiest motivation in the world to figure out,” he said, sitting back down at the table. “Some people knew I was still alive. I kept thinking I could keep him safe, but after a particularly close call... let’s just say I pray you never have to make the kind of decision I made that day.”

Mary dearly missed her telepathy right now, because she was having a hard time not believing the sadness and concern in Globe’s eyes. She could barely even think of him that way. In fairness, not many people are able to look intimidating while wearing a frilly apron.

“I don’t understand you,” Mary admitted after a moment. “This isn’t what I ever expected talking to you would be like.”

“To your credit, you’re handling it much better than most people would.”

“No, I mean, how can you act so concerned about Vince? You’re a damn criminal, you just admitted that, and yet you still are asking me to give you time to have dinner with him?”

“Mary, I know this is hard to understand right now, but we humans are multi-faceted beings. For example, I can bake an excellent soufflé, but I am utterly incapable of writing poetry worth reading. See the conflict?”

“Actually, no, not really.”

“Good, because there isn’t any,” he replied. “Baking has nothing to do with writing, just as me being a criminal doesn’t mean I don’t love and worry about my son. It is possible to be a bad citizen and a good father.”

Mary took a moment to stir her tea, the desire to have something calming her nerves outweighing any residual fear she felt that he might have slipped something in it. This was Vince’s mind, so he couldn’t hurt her real body, and somehow she doubted that Vince finding her slumped over at the table suited his agenda.

“Okay, let’s strike a deal,” Mary said at last. “What are you willing to trade if I wait a little while to go have them wake up Vince?”

“You’ve been hanging around Nicholas Campbell too much,” Vince’s father said, a twinkle of amusement in his eyes. “I’ll give you three things: a promise, a bit of advice, and a message.”

“Sounds vague.”

“I could throw in another cup of tea,” he said. “Or you could listen to what I’m offering and decide if it’s worth it.”

“Couldn’t I just listen and then screw you over?”

“Yes, however I like to think our next generation of Heroes can conduct themselves with a bit more decorum than that. So what do you say?”

Mary added a bit of honey to her tea and stirred it in.

“Deal. Now start talking.”



## 165.

Vince came back to reality slowly, grogginess tempering his perception as he slowly sat up on the surprisingly comfortable hospital cot. The first thing he noticed was his blurry vision, but close on its heels was a sense of overwhelming thirst. Luckily, a blurry glass was shoved into his line of sight before he even had to try and articulate this problem.

“Drink it all,” Dean Blaine instructed unnecessarily as the student grabbed the glass and begun taking the water in over-sized gulps. “Mr. Weaver’s ability has the strange side effect of leaving its victims with cotton mouth, and the longer the duration of being under, the worse it is.”

The glass was empty in no time, so Dean Blaine refilled it from a carafe on a nearby table. This process repeated three more times before Vince felt there was adequate moisture in his throat to speak.

“Rich put me under.”

“While we generally discourage the use of powers on other students outside of class, in this case I think it was a prudent call. It seems you had a bit of an uncontrolled reaction at the news footage.”

Vince swallowed hard and felt a tickle of pain still lingering in his throat. “Did I hurt anyone?”

“Not a soul. Mr. Weaver reacted before the bit of fire you were releasing could spread. Once you were out the flames dissipated quickly. No one even got so much as a hot flash,” Dean Blaine assured him, handing over another glass of water. This one Vince sipped slowly, letting it wash over his throat in small increments. “They brought you here as soon as you were stable, and your friends have been watching over you ever since. In fact, once Mr. Weaver released you there was quite a tussle getting them all to leave the room.” That was an understatement if ever he’d told one. Dean Blaine had been certain that Camille Belden was going to scratch and bite before she went willingly. Only Stella and Violet had been able to get her to temporarily retreat.

“They wanted to stay?”

“Don’t be stupid, of course they wanted to stay. You have very loyal friends, Vince. Never doubt that. I just felt it would be better if only I were

here when you awoke.”

“In case I was still out of control.”

“Yes, that is certainly part of it. I’m glad to see such is not the case,” Dean Blaine admitted.

“I owe that to Rich, I guess. He made a pretty incredible dream for me. I got to talk things out with my father and put everything in perspective.”

“Mr. Weaver only provides a template and a suggestion,” Dean Blaine informed him. “In this case, he told you to go somewhere safe and work through what you’d seen on the screen. He left you with a fleeting awareness of reality and a compulsion to make peace with your father. That was it, all the rest was you.”

“I think I still owe him anyway,” Vince said.

“Unquestionably,” Dean Blaine agreed.

“So, what was the other part? You said you only stayed here in part to make sure I didn’t lose control of myself.”

“I needed to tell you that what you saw on that television has changed everything,” Dean Blaine said, his voice heavy with responsibility. “It was bad enough when you had a potential connection to a deceased former Hero, but with the revelation of him being alive and the confirmation that he is indeed the man who raised you... the time to come will not be an easy one for you.”

Vince nodded and downed more of his water.

“I’ve been keeping most of the parties interested in you at bay,” Dean Blaine continued. “I will continue to do so as best I can; however, this has opened new doorways for them, ones that I cannot, and in all good conscience should not, block.”

“What will they want from me?”

“To ask you questions about Globe, to know about everything he ever said to you and what you two did together. They’ll be combing through your testimony for any clues that could lead to his capture. They will doubtlessly petition to bring in a telepath, but thankfully courts have ruled that no person can be forced to submit to a telepathic reading unless they are charged with a crime.”

“Couldn’t they just bring one in and not tell me?”

“They could, although that information would be equivalent to breaking into a home and recovering evidence without a warrant. Not only would it be inadmissible, it would invalidate anything connected to it. Still, there are some who would try it in a case like this, which is why I’ll be with you for every interview that is conducted.”

“You don’t have to do that, sir.”

“I most certainly do, just as I’d have to do the same for any other student here. While you are enrolled in the Hero Certification Program at Lander, you are all my responsibility. That means it is up to me to protect the outside world from your untrained abilities, but it is just as much my job to protect you from factions in the outside world who would take advantage of your relative inexperience. I assure you, while these interrogation sessions are likely unavoidable, they will proceed with everything on the up and up. That much, at least, I can still do.”

“Thank you very much,” Vince said, setting down his empty glass. “I’m starting to get the feeling this is about more than just Globe.”

“It shouldn’t, however it probably will be,” Dean Blaine said. “What you five students are, and more importantly what you were, has gotten a lot of people very interested. It was far more manageable before Mr. Clark’s outburst last year. We’ve still managed to contain any official leaks about your existence. Sadly, that doesn’t stop rumors or determined investigators.”

“So they want to know about the process?”

“They wanted that since last summer. No, what they’ll want now is to know exactly what the son of Globe can do, and once they realize how strong you are, the question will shift from ‘what’ to ‘why’, which is silly because no answer will satisfy them. That’s all to come; for right now you need to rest and recover. Final match is in a week, you know.”

“Oh yeah,” Vince said.

“I’ll go let your friends in now, before they decide to riot and cost me yet another door.” He was halfway across the room when Vince called to him.

“Dean, all this help. It isn’t just because I’m student, is it?”

Dean Blaine sighed; the boy might not have Campbell’s perception but he did have his father’s gift for seeing right to the bone of a person.

“Not entirely, no. Your father and I were in the same class, and we worked together on more than one assignment. Before he was a villain, Globe was a friend of mine, and he saved my life on many occasions. Heroes help each other; it’s part of the code we live by. I can’t do anything for him, not since he’s just committed another crime on national television. So if nothing else, I can at least look after his son.”

There was no more talk before Dean Blaine left the room, leaving the door open to the flood of Vince’s fellow students clamoring through it.

“Not so fast. I’ll have you know I’m a delicate sunflower,” Nick protested. Mary paid no heed, dragging him through the Melbrook entrance and over into the girls’ lounge. Snapping the door shut behind them, she paused to listen for the thoughts of Mr. Numbers or Mr. Transport. Both were absent, and with everyone else back at the infirmary waiting for Vince to come around, that meant they had the dorm to themselves.

Perfect.

“So are you going to tell me why you dragged me away from my buddy’s bedside or what?” Nick asked, flopping into one of the sizable plush chairs.

Mary paused long enough to gather her thoughts. What she’d learned from Globe, or even that he’d been there, all of it was too much to deal with. She didn’t know who she should tell, or how much she should reveal to other people. Too much could cause Vince to break down again, too little could result in an unexpected catastrophe. It was a morally grey area with large-scale implications, which was way out of Mary’s wheelhouse. Thankfully, she knew someone who felt right at home in these situations.

“I talked to Globe while I was in Vince’s head,” Mary told Nick.

“Can’t say I blame you; I’d be tempted too. Then again, my money says he was sort of boring given how Vince remembers him.”

Mary shook her head. “Not Vince’s memory of his dad. Globe. The real Globe. He was there, just like me.”

Had the situation not been so dire, Mary likely would have savored the look of genuine shock that came over Nick’s face. He leaned forward slowly, his hands coming together under his chin and a slight wrinkle appearing in his forehead. It was strange how with a few minute changes the carefree version of Nick could seamlessly evaporate away, leaving a very serious young man in his place.

“Tell me everything.”

So she did, explaining how she kept tabs on Vince in the dream, prodded him the right direction, went to check on him only to meet Globe, and how he asked her for more time with his son.



“I assume you did it,” Nick said as they reached that point in the story.

“With that deal? I’d be stupid not to.”

“Agreed. Were the results good enough to make it worthwhile?”

Mary nodded. “They were. And I didn’t see the harm in giving Vince a little more time with his father.”

“So what was the promise?”

“That he wouldn’t try to kidnap any of us again, nor would he allow anyone who worked for him to,” Mary recounted.

“Kind of a shitty promise now that we’re all watching for him.”

“I said more or the less the same thing. Then he reminded me that he’d just broken a heavily-guarded man out of a prison that was supposed to be impenetrable.”

“The man does know how to make a point,” Nick complimented.

“Indeed. He made another as well. What we are, and what we represent, it’s not a small thing. Many people are very interested in us, and it’s not impossible that they might try to kidnap one of us and hope he gets blamed,” Mary said. “So his promise only tells us that we’re safe from him, and that if one of us goes missing not to waste time chasing him down as a suspect.”

“I see the value, but I find it strange. What was so compelling about you last year that has now devalued so much that he won’t even try for it?”

“I get the feeling they hoped my kidnapping would succeed, but that they didn’t necessarily expect it to. Whatever piece of his plan that was, it seems like they’re past the part where it was useful. If he’s telling the truth.”

“From what you say, it sounds like Vince got his ability to lie or deceive from his father, so for the moment let’s assume he’s being honest,” Nick concluded. “Next was the piece of advice.”

“Right. This is where it gets a little weird. The promise was given to all of us. But you’re the one he wanted to receive the advice.”

Nick’s impassive stare gave away nothing; he merely motioned for Mary to continue.

“Globe wanted you to know that Vince is much stronger than any of

us realize, and that his kindness is both the cage that holds him back and the key to unleashing his potential. Does that make sense to you?”

“Did he actually say ‘any of us’ in that statement?” Nick said back.

“Yeah. Exactly those words. He even seemed to emphasize them. Why?”

“Never mind for now. I need to ruminate on that for a bit before I can give a complete answer. What about the last one? The message?”

“That’s the one I understand the least,” Mary admitted. “Since dream-walking isn’t his ability, he had to call in a favor from someone who could get him there. He just asked me to tell Alice the name of the Super who brought him into Vince’s mind.” Mary started to say the name, but she was interrupted by Nick.

“Fuck!” Nick hopped up from the chair and began prowling about the room. “I’ve been afraid this would happen. You cannot tell Alice the name until after our final match. Promise me that, Mary.”

“Why? I didn’t even tell you what it was.”

“It doesn’t matter what it was, I already know what it means, and Alice will too the moment she hears it. The second that happens she will be completely unreliable, at least for a while. That cannot happen right now. Especially since Vince just became the confirmed son of the world’s most wanted villain.”

“So I should keep it to myself?”

“Only until after the final match. One week, Mary, that’s all I’m asking for. After that, not only can you tell Alice, I’ll even help deal with the ramifications. For Alice’s own sake, and for the rest of ours, especially Vince’s, please just give me one week.”

“Fine,” Mary said after a long moment to think. She’d come to Nick because she trusted his judgment in these affairs. It wouldn’t make much sense to throw out his advice, especially since he seemed to genuinely care. “So what about the rest of the information? Is there something we should do with it?”

“Absolutely,” Nick replied. “The first part is to get Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport in on this. We’re going to need a lot of help with the next step, because you haven’t even realized the question that should have dawned on

you by now.”

“Which is?”

Nick stopped pacing and strode over to her, far closer than Mary was comfortable with. He leaned in and lowered his sunglasses, giving her a rare stare with his naked eye.

“How did Globe know that Rich put Vince under in the first place?”

There is a common discussion topic posed by philosophers who fancy themselves scientifically capable and scientists who have gotten thoroughly drunk: What would happen if an unstoppable force were to meet an immovable object? The folly in this discussion lies in the inescapable fact that neither of these things can exist. Both imply a limitless amount of mass or energy, and even in a world where certain humans can occasionally bend the laws of physics, all things have their limits. That said, there are objects that, while not immovable, possess sufficient staying power as to make the act of attempting to move them a highly likely exercise in absolute futility.

Camille Belden, sitting in a plastic chair at the side of Vince's infirmary bed, was currently such an object. She'd rebuffed the attempts by the healers to get her to leave by pointing out that, as a healer herself, she was not bound by things like visiting hours. She'd politely declined invitations from Stella or Violet to go grab a quick bite while Vince slept, though she had accepted the food they eventually brought her. Dean Blaine had popped back in at one point, and while he'd given her a curious glance or two, he'd made no efforts to convince her to give up her seat. Such was the benefit of experience: he knew a hopeless battle when he saw one.

Vince had been predominantly resting since the departure of the crowd of friends checking on him. Evidently whatever Rich did was different from sleep, because Vince had quickly realized how exhausted he was. The others noticed the yawns and left. Camille pulled up her chair and sat. She'd offered a weak excuse of staying in case he had any unexpected side effects and needed healing. She doubted even Vince was naïve enough to buy it. Camille knew she wasn't doing a good job at hiding how she felt. Eventually, she would care about that.

There was no gentle holding of his hand as she watched him, nor any carefully placed touches against his forehead. Camille's dainty hands lay in her lap, their tremendous potential to heal or hurt restrained with the lack of physical contact. Those sweet gestures were things a lover would do. That was not her. She had no illusions about her role in his life. Camille had gone to great lengths to cast herself this way, a pillar of support in his trying times, a friend he could always lean on. It meant she could always be near him, and the cost was that she could never close the final bit of space and touch him. Not the way a lover would. Not the way she wanted to.

Vince didn't need a lover; there would always be women drawn to his strong character and simple, honest manner. What he needed was someone to watch over him, because despite all his good traits, the boy didn't have more than a thin flicker of self-preservation. He would always charge headlong into situations where people were in need, not paying more than passing heed to whether or not he could actually survive. It was the thing that Camille loved the most about him. It was the thing she knew would ultimately kill him. There was no hope of changing him, of making him more cautious. Even if she could, that would just be a crueler way of killing off Vince Reynolds. No, all she could do was stay close and push back that inevitable day for as long as possible. What she might have wanted to be, to him, with him, in a perfect world, was irrelevant. Not when it was weighed against the risk of seeing him leave this world even one instant sooner than was avoidable.

He stirred, rolling over and blinking the groggy remainders of sleep from his eyes.

"Hey," he said, his voice rougher than normal. "How long was I out?"

"You've been sleeping for around five hours," Camille replied.

"Feels like I just nodded off." He sat up in bed and took a long stretch. "You weren't here the whole time, were you?"

"Of course not," she lied. "All the healers have been taking turns keeping an eye on you. It looks like we weren't needed."

"Doesn't seem so," Vince agreed. "Sorry you guys wasted the time watching me."

She gave him a small smile. "Vince, people with my kind of ability are always happier when we don't have to use it. It means no one had to suffer in the first place."

"Never thought about it like that." He finished his stretching and pulled off the covers. The uniform he'd been wearing was wrinkled nearly beyond recognition. Thankfully they'd taken the jacket off him before putting his body in bed. That was, by far, the hardest part to iron.

"How are you feeling?"

"Still a little tired, but overall I think I'm fine," Vince informed her.

"I didn't mean physically."

“I know.” He looked away from her, his eyes wandering to a clock slowly ticking and tocking from its perch on the wall. “I think I’m going to need some time to really make peace with everything. I mean, Rich’s dream thing helped me get past the worst of it, but it’s still a lot to deal with. At least it’s not all bad.”

“It’s not?”

“My father is alive,” he said, turning back and giving her a wide grin. Vince had no talent in hiding his feelings, or perhaps his talent was simply that he felt no compulsion to do so. Although the worry and uncertainty were still evident on his face, so was the unequivocal joy he was feeling at that realization. “I might get to see him again, to talk to him. I admit, it’s not exactly a perfect situation, but it’s still more than I ever really could have hoped for.”

“You know this is going to make things harder on you, right? The fact that you were raised by him would have been a big deal even if he were still dead. Him being alive compounds that times ten.”

“I know. Dean Blaine and I had a chat about it earlier,” he said. “Still, if my choices were this situation or my father turning out to not have been Globe but still being dead, I’d be sitting in this infirmary bed after a literal meltdown every time. Just knowing he’s alive makes it worth it, no matter how much trouble or pain is going to come along with it. Think that’s crazy?”

“Not at all,” Camille said. She understood exactly how he felt.

Chad tried to ignore the steady repetition of knuckles against his dorm room door. He'd been doing well for half an hour, but it was plain the person on the other side wasn't giving up. He could have turned himself deaf, but then he might have missed a call from his mother. She would have been at work all day, and she wasn't one to watch the news, but it was inevitable that she would see what happened, that He was still alive. Chad could ignore a lot of things with impunity, today especially. The call she would surely make to him was not one of those things.

Giving up, he walked over to the door and pulled it open. Shane and Angela stood on the other side. A quick glance at the light bruising on their hands told him they'd been trading off turns knocking on the door. It spoke volumes that these two siblings had been able to work together with such efficiency and manage to not dissolve into bickering. Chad said nothing; he simply walked back to his bed and sat down. Angela plopped down in his desk chair, while Shane seemed to prefer standing. The door swung shut and silence regained its sovereign rule, which proved to be a brief respite.

"How you doing there, Slugger?" Angela asked, spinning slowly in the chair as it made circles.

"Slugger?" Shane's voice was exasperated, but not surprised.

"You think I should have gone with Sport, or Ace?"

"I think you should, maybe just this once, show a situation the respect that it's due."

"Ohh, you mean be boring and gentle and tiptoe around the fact that the guy who iced Chad's dad just showed up alive on the news. Or maybe you think I should ice-skate over the fact that he has a kid in class with you two."

"For God's sake, Angela. Do you have any bit of sensitivity in you?"

"Only in spots I am damned sure not going to talk about with my brother in the room. If you want to get scarce, I might be willing to do some divulging with Chad."

There was a snort of sound that interrupted them, a noise more foreign to Shane than Angela. It took him a moment to realize that Chad had allowed a small laugh to escape from his solemn face.

“There we go, I knew you were alive in there after all,” Angela said, bringing her spinning chair to a careful halt. “See, that’s the problem with you, Shane. You go into a serious situation and want to make it more serious. Friends lighten shit up.”

“Right, hinting that you’d bang my friend if I left is clearly what every psychologist in America would recommend doing in this situation.”

“This situation? You say that like this has happens three times a month. I think we’ve officially set sail in uncharted waters.”

“Green Genes.” This one came from Chad, and managed to quiet the siblings’ sniping immediately. “Happened twenty-seven years ago. A Hero known as Green Genes lost control during a battle and accidentally killed another Hero called The Chairman. Rather than face charges, he faked his own death in order to undertake a covert mission infiltrating a gang of criminal Supers. Five years later he returned from the dead. The Chairman had two children that had to find out the man who killed their father was still alive. So, not entirely uncharted waters.”

“Why in the hell have we not taken you to do trivia night at one of the bars around here?” Angela asked.

“What happened to Green Genes?” Shane added, working in vain to try and keep his sister focused on the issue at hand.

“He died in the line of duty three years after coming back from his fake death. No foul play was suspected.”

“Here’s a better question: what happened to The Chairman’s kids?” Angela tossed out.

“Neither of them were Super, so they went about their lives normally. There are reports that Green Genes visited the family frequently, helping out in whatever ways he could. He spent the rest of his life trying to make up for what he’d taken away from them. By all accounts it was as cordial a relationship as you can have with a parent’s killer. When he died, they even went to his funeral.”

“I think we have a very different situation then,” Shane observed.

Chad shrugged, his face still largely impassive. “The man who killed my father is alive. I don’t expect he’ll be stopping by to beg my forgiveness, but then again, I didn’t expect to see him on the news today either. I don’t



know how to go forward from here. I know I want to meet him, to fight him, probably even to kill him. More than anything, I want to ask him why.” Chad’s voice did not crack on the word why, nor did any moisture appear in his eyes, which only demonstrated the true extent of his power over bodily control.

“Maybe one day you’ll get the chance,” Shane said.

“True. Or we could go beat up his kid and see if he knows anything,” Angela suggested.

“If Vince knew his father was Globe, or that he was alive, then he is an actor of such spectacular talent that we would never be able to glean any truth from him,” Chad replied. “I don’t bear him any ill will in all of this. In a strange way, I suspect he and I are going through a lot of the same feelings.”

Angela opened her mouth, no doubt with some sarcastic barb or inappropriate quip; however, she was interrupted by a crisp knock on Chad’s door. She and Shane exchanged glances of confusion. Chad was their friend, but the rest of his social circle was somewhat limited. They knew Roy had stopped by to help last time, but it seemed more likely he’d be with his own people, looking after Vince. Shane walked over, gave a quick glance through the peephole, and pulled open the door.

“Thank you, Mr. DeSoto,” Dean Blaine said stiffly. “Chad, I was wondering if I could have a word with you?”

“Sure,” Chad replied, not looking at the door.

The dean stood still for a moment, then turned his gaze toward Angela and Shane. He said nothing, but the message could not have been clearer.

“We’ll swing by tomorrow for breakfast,” Shane said, heading toward the door.

“Or any time tonight if you need to talk. Or spar, I know how you love to spar. Just call me. Any time. I mean it.” The genuine concern and lack of lightness in Angela’s voice stunned everyone in the room. It was one of the secrets she knew well: if you gave very few things weight then the ones you did were all the more powerful.

Dean Blaine shut the door behind the DeSotos then turned to Chad. “I’ve gotten an old friend to teleport us to your house whenever you’re ready. She’s aware of the news and is waiting for us. You’re excused from the next

week of classes, but I'm afraid it's not in my power to get you out of the final match."

"That's fine," Chad said, his voice still calm and detached. "Thank you. When do we leave?"

"As soon as you feel composed enough to go."

"Composed?" Even as he said it, Chad noticed the sudden rush of thickness to his voice and the way the room had grown blurry. People often forget that emotions come with, and often from, chemical shifts in the brain. Unless he was caught by surprise, Chad's ability allowed him to keep such things under constant control. With Dean Blaine in the room, that control had been suspended, and now Chad was subject to all the things he'd been working so very hard not to feel.

Chad placed his face in his hands as the last shreds of his composure dissolved in a torrent of tears.

It was Tuesday when Nick slid into a seat adjacent to Vince, both of them currently in the boys' lounge of Melbrook. Vince was studying for his last final exam, or at least he had been before Nick arrived. The sophomores had been blessed with more free time than expected, their duties at the carnival had been absorbed by the juniors and seniors. Officially this was because the committee meeting had been interrupted before tasks could be assigned. The actual reason could be speculated on, but since Dean Blaine was immune to both telepathic probing and idle dissemination of information, speculation was all it would remain.

"Working hard, or hardly working?"

Vince closed his book. Whatever Nick wanted, it was likely going to require Vince's full attention. "Just trying to squeeze in as much as I can."

"You never learn, do you? Cramming doesn't... screw it, a fight for another time. I wanted to see how you were holding up."

"Better than I would have thought myself capable of. Honestly, with the stress of finals and the impending match, I haven't had much time to think about the Globe incident."

"That's great, but that's actually not what I'm talking about."

Vince's brow furrowed. That was all pretty much anyone had asked him about since it happened. It hadn't occurred to him Nick might be concerned about something else.

"Don't give me that look. You're obviously fine with the Globe being your father issue, otherwise you'd be holed up in your room, crazier than a shithouse rat. That's not the sort of thing you can fake your way through."

"I guess?"

"You guess right." Nick leaned forward and plucked the book from Vince's hand. "What you can carry under the surface as it eats at you is the same problem we've been fighting against since day one: your fear of your own power."

"I thought I'd been making progress."

"Tremendous strides. But what no one seems to have talked about yet

was your fiery freak-out before Rich put you under. That shouldn't bother you; I daresay nearly anyone in your situation would have lost some form of control. You being you, I'm betting it's been slithering around in the back of your mind, making you wonder if you've really gained as much control as you think you need."

"Oh." Vince studied his hands intently. No one had mentioned that incident save for his discussion with Dean Blaine. He'd hoped, well, he didn't know what he'd hoped. Maybe that he could pretend it didn't happen. "Yeah, it scared me. I could have really hurt someone. It's just lucky that Rick stopped me."

"I don't blame you for being a little scared," Nick said, opening the book and leafing through it. Whether his eyes were on the pages or not, only the sunglasses knew. "All of us have that little phobia ticking away somewhere inside of us. Wondering if we'll go back, if this has all just been a sweet teasing taste of a life we can never have. You and I, we have a greater fear than the others. If we suddenly revert, it might not just be ourselves that suffer."

"This isn't really making me feel better," Vince said.

"I'm just saying you don't have to be ashamed of having that fear. What should shame you is if you let it hold you down. Mastering your ability is the best defense you have against losing control of it."

"You realize I can count on one hand the number of times I've seen you use your power, right?" Vince pointed out.

"You can count on one hand the number of times I've told you I used my power," Nick corrected. He gently jiggled the sunglasses stretched across his face. "These bad boys aren't just for making me look cool. Of course, they do that pretty well too. None of which is the point of this discussion. I just want to make sure you aren't backsliding into the Vince who shows up carrying the energy equivalent of a lighter. We've got days until we'll be facing who knows what, and I'm counting on you being in fighting form."

"I'm not going to let you down," Vince said. Despite the flighty body language he'd displayed during the talk, Nick recognized a familiar resilience in his voice. Years ago he would have mistaken it for Vince trying to convince himself that he would be able to follow through. After all they'd been through, Nick now knew it was the sound of his friend when things got serious. He liked that tone; it meant the realms of possibility were about to

dramatically shift.

“Good. Our team is counting on you.” Nick set the book back in Vince’s hands, then began to rise from his seat.

“It’s me, isn’t it?”

Nick froze in mid-air, his long arms still pressing against the chair as he propelled himself upward. Slowly he lowered back into the warm and waiting cushions below his posterior. He debated lying, or trying to cover with misdirection, but neither of those would likely succeed. Vince was easily led and deceived most of the time; when he found the truth, however, there was no separating him from it.

“Yeah. It’s you. It’s been you ever since your secret got out at Camille’s birthday party. There were people who wanted you gone, and that was when the whole thing was a crazy rumor.”

Vince nodded; clearly this meshed with whatever had already been in his head. “Why didn’t you just tell me? Why pretend it was about protecting the others?”

“Firstly, protecting the others wasn’t pretend. This is an elimination game, don’t ever forget that. Just because you were in the crosshairs didn’t mean a poor showing wouldn’t push some of us out the door along with you. As to why I emphasized that part, well, I mean, come on. You have to have noticed this about yourself by now. You never fight as hard as when you’re protecting other people.”

“Everyone is like that,” Vince said. “We all fight hardest when others are on the line.”

Nick opened his mouth with a smart-ass reply then glanced in his friend’s eyes. They were teeming with a sentiment of honest belief. The stupid kid really thought the rest of the world functioned like he did. He didn’t understand that most people looked out for themselves first and most vehemently then gave consideration to the rest of the world. Sure, a reasonable percentage might go to the walls for their family, but it didn’t match the raw animal savagery they would use when fighting for their own life. Nick had seen it time after countless time. People looked out for themselves. Well... most people.

“Then why are you surprised that I emphasized it?” Nick said at last. There was no need to try and rupture Vince’s pretty image of the world, not

that Nick was certain he could even if he tried. “You know people work that way, so obviously that’s why I would have used it to motivate you.”

“It does make sense, when you put it like that,” Vince replied. He reopened his book, flipping through the pages until he returned to his spot. “You don’t have to worry. I have no intention of letting anyone on this team get kicked out. Myself included.”

“Now that’s what I like to hear,” Nick said, patting his friend on the shoulder and leaving him to his studies.

## 170.

“Good morning to you all,” Dean Blaine greeted, his strong voice rebounding off the gym’s walls and crashing into the twenty-seven students clustered before him. Gathered around them were their six professors, standing at strategic points as though they were anticipating a sudden stampede toward the exit. It had happened before.

“Today is the final team match of your sophomore year, and it will also serve as the examination for entrance into the junior class. Of those gathered today, at best only twenty will be returning. I encourage you to do your best, for the sake of yourself and those who share a team number with you. After today teams will cease to exist; however, I hope you will all remember this experience, and understand the importance of trusting, depending on, and working with other Supers. It is our greatest advantage over the criminal element, and one we should utilize at every opportunity. Captains, raise your hands!”

Four hands went up, some higher than others, but all without an instant of hesitation. Chad’s outstretched fingers were the tallest, and if any lingering worries or neurosis from last week’s revelation remained in him they were certainly not discernible in the blonde boy’s steely gaze. Four of the professors, Stone, Hill, Cole, and Fletcher, moved through the crowd and deposited an object in each of the raised hands.

“Your instructors are currently handing you each a single orb with your team number inscribed in it. That orb will remain in your possession until the match begins,” Dean Blaine continued. “Once we start, you are free to give it to anyone on your team that you see fit. You will all be dropped at various locations in the arena. Your goal is to get that orb to a depository at its center. Finding it will not be difficult, I assure you of that much.”

The captains were turning the orbs around in their hands, examining them. Each was cold and metallic, with a single digit carved into the smooth surface.

“There will be no traps or obstacles, save for the natural terrain, blocking you from the goal. The challenge you will face is much greater. It is each other. The depository will be indeed easy to find; however, it will also only be open for five minutes, occurring exactly two hours after the match begins. Any orbs not placed inside before the deadline will not be counted.

Additionally, placing any ball in the depository will gain your team five points, whether it belongs to you or another team.”

There was a murmur of understanding that rippled through them. Dean Blaine greatly preferred the students he dealt with once they reached this point. They’d been through enough that hand-holding during explanations was required far less often.

“I see you already understand what that means. I would like to remind you that your professors and I will be watching, and that use of intentionally deadly force will lead to a student’s immediate disqualification. Such a ruling would not bode well for their evaluation on entrance into next year’s class. Keep it civil, and do your best. You have five minutes before we leave for the arena.”

The crowd, already gathered close to their teams, immediately split off to separate corners of the gym. It wouldn’t stop people like Chad and Amber from overhearing their words, or Alex and Mary from listening to their thoughts, but it was still an ingrained habit to create distance when discussing sensitive issues.

“Seven card stud?” Mary asked Nick as soon as Team One had all arrived in the southwestern section of the gym.

Nick scratched his head. “That might be for the best. Optimum coverage and all.” They’d developed a few terms for their strategies the night before in preparation of being overheard. Without knowing what they were facing, it was better to have at least a couple of pre-arranged strategies in their hip pocket. Seven card stud was all of them going off on their own, five card draw was five respective teams, Roy, Alice, and Alex all going off on their own. Hearts would have meant they defaulted to the same pairs as the first match, and Fifty-Two Pickup meant they were fucked and had to think of something on the fly.

“No.”

It took Nick a minute to figure out who had said that, he was so unaccustomed to hearing the voice speak without prompting. Camille was staring up at him - in fairness she’d have had to stare up to look any of her team in the eye - with an uncompromising gaze.

“Don’t like that one?”

“I don’t. I think it spreads us too thin. We’re better with at least a few



pairs.”

“I see,” Nick said, resisting the urge to tug down his sunglasses and meet her stare. “There are dangers to that plan, too. Are you fully prepared for everything that it might entail?”

“Completely.” If there was any doubt or fear in her, Nick couldn’t find it. Still, it never hurt to double check. He glanced over at Mary, who gave him a firm nod. If between himself and a telepath they couldn’t sense any hesitation in her to do what was necessary, then it either wasn’t there or she had a tremendous career ahead of her in espionage.

“Fine; Camille raises a relevant concern. We don’t want to get caught with our pants down on this one. Five card draw.”

“Who holds the orb?” Vince asked.

“We’ll figure that out once we’re in the arena, or at least far enough from people who can overhear us,” Mary informed him. “Our team is the only one that can keep the element of surprise, so I have no intention of wasting it.”

“Nicely said,” Nick concurred. “Okay, folks, that hits the high points, the rest is self-explanatory. Mary will figure out who has the orbs. Hunt for those people, avoid everyone else. Oh, and one more thing.” He leaned in, inciting them to do the same. It wouldn’t do anything to damper those who could hear them, but it would put emphasis on his words. That was what mattered right now. He scanned the team as he spoke, but made sure to let his concealed gaze fall on Alice, Vince, and Camille especially.

“This is our last team match. Hold nothing back. Leave everything out there. All the games, and dances, and careful tricks we’ve used through the year have officially come to an end. Give it everything you’ve got, and let the chips fall where they may.”

“Crafty,” Mary said, her eyes closed as she listened to all of her competitors throughout the field. The rest of her team milled around her quietly, trying to keep their thoughts as silent as possible so as not to add to the mental ruckus. The starting bell had gone off a few minutes ago, but rather than dash off all at once, they were waiting for her to figure out who would be holding each team’s orb. As for where to go, that much at least was quite evident.

Some distance away, impossible to judge through the trees of this arena, a giant beam of red light stretched from the ceiling down below the tree line, presumably to the floor. It didn’t take a great leap of intuition to figure out this was the depository Dean Blaine had told them about. Unfortunately, knowing where they needed to end up wasn’t the same as knowing where to go until then.

“Okay, I’ve got it pieced together,” Mary said at last, opening her eyes and getting to her feet. “Team Two is trying to make me think that Chad has it, but a few of them slipped up and thought about the truth. They gave the orb to Julia. Sadly, that’s not a big help, since she’s split off into about a dozen clones, all of whom share the same mind. If you see one then go for it. Just know that as soon as one sees you the others will know your location, and a clone is going with every member of her team to pass along information.”

“Instant communication. Damn, that’s pretty good,” Nick complimented.

“Yes, but we always knew Chad’s team was going to be a beast to contend with. Shane came up with a pretty effective strategy as well. He gave the orb to Tiffani and paired her with Amber. Between her ability to make illusions and Amber’s sound manipulation, those two are going to be effectively invisible to everyone but myself and Alex,” Mary continued.

“Plus, Amber is a pretty heavy hitter in her own right,” Roy added. His pride wouldn’t let him forget how easily she’d dropped him during the maze fight freshman year.

“Very true. Britney took the most expected strategy; she held onto the orb and went invisible. She’s staying hidden and mobile while her team hunts for other orbs. Adam copied Allen, so they have two people able to fire

ranged energy explosions.”

“So, what do we do?” Vince asked.

“First we figure out who is going to hold onto our orb,” Mary said. “The obvious choices are myself and Alice.”

“Me?”

“You can fly up to the top of the arena and wait out the match in relative safety,” Nick pointed out. “That strategy isn’t perfect; there are still ways you could get reached if the other teams get creative. Besides, I hate to take one of our stronger abilities out of the game.”

“This from the guy who gave me a four,” Alice teased. They both knew the girl whose power ranked so low in the relative scale was long gone. What she could do now was nothing short of tremendous.

“I agree. Alice should stay in,” Alex concurred. “Especially since no one knows what she can do. Her power and the element of surprise are too good to give up.”

“Suggestions are heard. All right then, I’ll hold the orb. Any objections?” Mary asked.

“It’s what they’ll all expect,” Nick pointed out. “But that’s because it’s the smart call to make. You’ve got the range to detect people approaching and the power to knock them back if they get near.”

“Mary keeps the orb then; what do the rest of us do?”

“Alex should hunt down Britney, Mary and I will go after Amber and Tiffani,” Nick replied. “The rest of you fan out in your formations and hope we get lucky and find the right Julia. I’ll supply what help I can in that regard.”

“I think I should go after Amber and Tiffani,” Alex protested.

“Alex, Amber is very powerful,” Camille said gently.

“Which is why it should be me. In case you guys forgot our last match, I’m the only one with practice deflecting soundwaves. Mary has gotten a lot better in training, but I don’t think she’ll be able to pull it off. Sorry.” He said the last part to her with a look of slight embarrassment. Alex took no joy in pointing out the shortcomings of others; he merely wanted to give his team the best chance it had. Luckily for him, Mary had already made

peace with the fact that there were some things he could do that she never would.

“No, you’re absolutely right,” Mary agreed. “You go after Amber and Tiffani, Nick and I will hunt for Britney.”

“Wouldn’t it make more sense for Nick to crank up his luck and find the right Julia?” Alice asked.

“And if I did, and she was with one of the combat members of her team, what purpose would that serve? I got skills, but they aren’t enough for me to take down a trained Super,” Nick said.

“Except for all the times you’ve done just that,” Vince added.

“That was just Gilbert. Mary made the right call on this one. First we hunt Britney, and then we go after Julia.”

“If the three of you are going to try and get the orbs then why don’t we stay with you?” Camille pointed out.

“This is a numbers game,” Nick explained. “If we can find Britney, and if my luck happens to work the way I’m hoping and lead me to Julia, and if that clone of Julia isn’t guarded by someone like Chad, and if we can do all of this in time to make it to the depository, then sure, it would be a great plan. That’s a lot of ifs. It makes more sense to send you guys out separately and increase our chances. Besides, this isn’t just about what we do, it’s about how we do it. Going off in different directions increases our chances of showcasing our various skills.”

“Makes sense to me,” Roy said. Vince and Alex nodded their agreement as well. Camille merely stepped to Vince’s side in preparation for departure.

“Looks like we’ve got a plan then,” Alice quipped.

“That we do. The others have already begun to move while we were talking, so everyone stay alert and keep safe,” Mary cautioned. “And move fast. We’ve got less than two hours to show everyone what this team can really do.”

Roy didn't have much of a plan as he jogged through the patches of forest. He knew he didn't want to get near the giant pillar of red light; it was too early for anyone to be congregating around it. He also knew that any attempts at stealth were a waste of time. Roy didn't want to go unnoticed, he wanted to fight. So instead of creeping and crawling along the ground, he just jogged casually in a wide circle around the beacon. He figured sooner or later he was bound to run into someone. If it was Julia, that would work, and if it was anyone else, he would make do. What he really wanted was to run into someone like Chad or Shane, someone he could truly pit his new strength against. Roy didn't exactly get his wish, but it wasn't too far off.

He felt his leg go out from under him as it was jerked quickly into the air. He found himself hanging upside down, a bright orange hand of energy wrapped around his ankle leading along a glowing path back to Thomas. The two looked at each other in silence for a moment, two warriors taking the measure of their opponent. Roy had never fought Thomas, but he knew the boy's ability from Vince and Alex's match against him in the maze. He didn't imagine this would be too hard.

"You aren't very quiet when you run," Thomas observed.

"Nope," Roy agreed.

"I suppose that means they didn't give you an orb."

"Go figure, they didn't think I would do a good job of staying hidden."

"You're going to tell me which of your teammates has it."

Roy flashed Thomas an upside down grin. "You're welcome to make me try, but I gotta warn you: I've gotten a lot stronger than the last time anyone saw me fight."

"You don't say." Thomas gathered his internal energy and prepared for the impending battle. Roy was a powerful opponent; he always had been. But unbeknownst to Roy, his team didn't have a monopoly on people finding new ways to use their skills.

\* \* \*

Vince and Camille were walking with care through the brush, trying as best they could to muffle their movements. He was far more adept than she was: a life of sneaking onto and off of railway lines will impart a generous amount of talent in stealth. However, even Vince wasn't quite good enough to avoid detection. Neither of them heard their attacker approach, neither of them saw the practiced flick of his wrist. The first clue Vince had that they'd been attacked was the searing pain that ripped through his left leg. He let out a gasp and tumbled forward. Camille reached for him but found herself thrown backward, landing in a heavy heap ten feet away from her fallen friend.

"I loathe sneak attacks," Shane said, stepping out from a small pine cluster and into a clear area. "I sincerely do. Even knowing they're a recognized piece of strategy, they still make me feel dirty. I'm sorry I had to use one, but Vince is simply too dangerous to fight head on."

The dangerous man in question was currently pushing through his pain. He tried to pull himself up and discovered that his right leg was worthless. Somehow Shane had cut his Achilles tendon, leaving the appendage unable to bear any of his weight. He ignored it, years of training kicking into place as he steadied his mind and began to take aim.

"None of that," Shane said, another jerk of his hand precipitating a yelp of pain from Vince. This time Camille saw what happened: Vince's shadow contracted into a thin blade of vibrating darkness, leaping up from the ground and cutting into his shoulder.

"I don't mean to be cruel, but I'm not letting you work past the pain enough for a clear shot. Just surrender your orb if you have one, or tell me who I should be hunting. I'll still have to incapacitate you, but there is no reason to make that process any more painful than possible," Shane explained. He jerked his hand once more.

This time it was Camille who had to stifle a shout as she felt her leg go numb. This sent her crashing to the ground face first, since she'd been trying to sneak over to Vince and Shane.

"I can't let you do that either, Camille. Look, you are both very pleasant people and I bear you no ill will. Please don't make this hard on yourselves."

Had Vince's face not been pointed toward the ground Shane would have seen the silver-haired boy's eyes nearly watering with effort. He might

not have understood that Vince was thinking of all the people counting on him, of having to stand by while Shane incapacitated Camille, of feeling useless. What he would have gotten, almost assuredly, was some sort of warning about what Vince was trying to do. It likely wouldn't have made much of a difference. Vince was already resolved. If Shane wouldn't let him get off a clean shot, he would just have to settle for a dirty one.

Vince clutched his hands into fists and summoned up a torrent of fire that would have made a volcano feel impotent.

\* \* \*

Alice decided after the first few minutes that Mary's idea to take the high ground wasn't such a bad one. After all, anything she saw would be available to the telepaths, which would help them coordinate their search for the orb holders. Besides, Alice was a flier at heart; trudging along on the ground when the air was accessible just held no appeal to her.

She shot above the trees quickly, lest one of their ranged opponents get off a lucky shot, then slowed her ascent as she got clear of a surprise attack range. The ceiling was still some ways above her, though as she rose higher she could make out the blue paint and spaced out lights used to illuminate the field and create the illusion of a sky overhead. It was an impressive piece of work, but one that lost its luster when one drew too close. Alice was so absorbed in looking at the ceiling that she nearly missed the other human figure floating over to her.

"Fancy seeing you here," Violet greeted. "Guess we had the same idea."

"You can fly?"

"I can do a lot of things. Now how about you hand over the orb I'm sure you're packing and I won't have to show them to you."

Alice felt her lips draw tight as a mischievous grin crept across her face. Oh hell yes, this was going to be good.

## 173.

When he looked back on it later, Alex would realize that it was the same innocent curiosity formed during their relationship that allowed Selena to sneak up on him. Just as he had wondered if it was possible to deflect her ability, she'd tried to see if there was a way to avoid detection from his. It would take him some time longer to understand just how she'd done it, that she'd figured out he sensed the emotions and general sense of a person more than their specific thoughts and that she'd sung a song of emptiness to push those things down in all who heard it, but none of that information was available to him at the moment. All Alex knew was that he should have been safe, should have been far from anyone else as he moved toward the direction of Tiffani and Amber; however, he still rolled to the side when he heard a crackling sound from behind him.

The training with Alice and Mary might not have increased his raw force as much as they'd hoped, but it had damn sure helped train his reflexes. Alex jumped up and spun around, noticing a small smoking spot on the ground where he'd been standing, and faced the opponent who'd managed to sneak up on him. Jill stood there, her arm still raised and a small device glowing on her gauntlet. She was barely recognizable; the suit she wore had clearly undergone some serious modifications. It gleamed in the fake sunlight, dark metal flowing across her body, little notches and bumps giving away the various devices that she could call to action with a mere thought. All of it was topped off by a helmet with two barely-visible eye slots. It should have greatly obstructed her vision, but Alex knew Will's craftsmanship too well to count on such an oversight.

"Nice dodge," Jill said, her voice somewhat muffled by the apparatus enclosing her head. "You're getting better."

"You, too; you'll have to tell me how you managed to avoid my mental detection," Alex replied. As he spoke, he brought down the same telekinetic force he'd used on Will in the second match, pressing on her like she was a sandwich in a panini press. Unlike Will, she didn't immediately buckle. Her suit had either been formatted to increase her strength or somehow counter this exact strategy; knowing Will it was probably both. She did begin to go down slowly, her shoulders hunching and knees buckling outward. He was about to turn up the pressure when the song hit his ears. It was a song of slumber, one that made his head swim with visions of soft



pillows and thick blankets.

He glanced to the tree line and sure enough, there was Selena, singing her siren's lullaby. Alex switched into sound repelling mode, but the necessary focus meant he had to release Jill, who immediately called forth two new glowing devices to the gauntlets around her wrists.

"You were right," Jill called to her teammate. "Having Will create a sound negation device was a good idea." The handy doodad allowed her to fight in close proximity to Selena without falling under her spell unless Jill willingly deactivated the system. It was a good thing, too. Alex's ability meant he could very effectively counter either one of the girls in combat. Both of them working in tandem, on the other hand, now that was a task they doubted he'd be able to handle.

\* \* \*

"Things aren't going too hot, are they?"

Mary glanced at Nick, whose face wore an expression of practiced disinterest. If he'd been asking because he cared, one wouldn't know it from looking at him. Mary was used to that part; what concerned her was how unsurprised he seemed at the idea that their team was in trouble. It was especially impressive since she hadn't given him any updates since they separated.

"How did you know?"

"I didn't, I merely suspected. You'd be feeding me information about each person's victories if they were having any. Since you're silent I'm assuming it means they've hit a few obstacles."

"Too soon to tell," Mary replied. "But a few of them are in some tough fights. Vince and Camille are facing Shane, Alice is squaring off with Violet, Roy and Thomas are about to throw down, and Alex just got ambushed by Selena and Jill, with one of Julia's clones watching from a safe distance."

Nick made a clicking sound somewhere in his throat. "Fuck. That is not an ideal lineup for us."

"A couple of them could swing our way."

"Sure, but not the most important one."

“I think you’re underestimating Vince,” Mary said.

“I doubt it,” Nick shot back. “I’ve spent more time working with him than anyone else in this group. I’ve run endless scenarios in my head to try and prep him for as many of them that are winnable as possible. I think it’s safe to say that right now I know Vince’s abilities better than anyone else, himself included.”

“Except his father,” Mary pointed out.

“Allegedly. That cute little tip hasn’t been proven yet.”

“Yet?”

Nick gave a curt nod. “Keep me updated on their fight. Once I know how it shakes out, I’ll know how to proceed.”

“You have a plan for if he loses?”

“I have a plan for everything. I have a plan for Zeus blasting down through the ceiling and declaring himself the king of Naples. Just because I have one doesn’t make it particularly good.”

“I see.” They walked in silence for a bit longer, Mary redirecting them a few times as their target changed direction. Eventually Mary’s curiosity was too much, and reading Nick’s mind was no help as he was purposely obfuscating by doing complex math in his head.

“So, are you going to tell me what the plan is?”

“Make an offering to Nyarlathotep, one of the ancient dark gods of the abyss, to come and challenge Zeus for the throne. I figure if one god is real, why not others? While they duke it out, I hightail myself to safety. Then avoid Naples for the rest of my life.”

“I meant what’s the plan for if Vince loses?”

“Oh, I’m not going to share that one,” Nick said. “You’d hate it anyway. Far too much of a long shot.”

The trees were on fire, that much was evident to anyone nearby as well as to any students who took notice of the rising smoke and orange glow. Although Vince hated to damage property, he would have doubtlessly found the sacrifice to be worthwhile in exchange for defeating Shane. Unfortunately for him, that was not the case.

Vince's arms were both extended, his hand open with small waves of heat still emanating from them. Rather than being aimed near Shane, which he'd intended, they were facing a cluster of trees that were crackling as the flame turned them into kindling. Vince couldn't see them, he could only feel the vine-like appendages that had wrapped around his arms, jerking them to a new target at the last minute. Before he could even think of shifting his focus, those same restraints flexed against his arms. The next sensation Vince was aware of was searing pain and a sticky dampness down to his elbows.

"You always use your hands to aim," Shane commented. "It makes you predictable." His irises and sclera were gone, or at least they had turned so dark that they may as well have vanished. It gave the illusion that Shane's face bore empty sockets, ones that opened to a twisted void of a dimension encompassed in utter blackness. It was, to say the least, a bit unnerving, and not just because of the strange visage it gave him. Even after spending the year with him in Close Combat class, Vince and Camille were both impressed by his shadow manifestation and manipulation ability.

Vince was currently thinking less about how impressive it was and more about how much pain he was in. His arms were hanging uselessly: whatever muscles Shane cut had taken away Vince's ability to lift them above his waist. Trying to focus through the pain, Vince set his eyes on Shane and began to draw upon the electricity stored within.

"Enough." Shane made a quick hand motion, and Vince felt his feet go out from under him. A few attempted motions confirmed that several muscles in his legs had been severed. This time Shane hadn't tried to wound, he'd gone for incapacitation. Vince lay in the grass, his eyes still focused on his opponent, but another quick motion flipped him over and changed that as well.

"I hate to do this," Shane said, turning his attention to Camille. "I actually sort of enjoy both of you. You support your team, you train hard, and

you conduct yourselves with behavior appropriate for aspiring Heroes. Regardless of Vince's origin, I respect his ability. That's why I have to take him down; he represents too great an unknown factor in this game. Camille, you are simply collateral damage since you could revive him."

As Shane talked he manipulated the shadow on one of the larger trees, first turning it into a blade with which he sliced off a branch, then thickening it into a tendril which he used to heft up the tree limb he'd just cut down. He carted the branch over and set it, surprisingly carefully, down on top of Camille.

"There, that should keep you from going over to him," Shane said once the task was done. "You can breathe, right?"

Camille couldn't form words; the seething rage at seeing Vince sliced into ribbons had her head pounding and her tongue thick. Instead she stared daggers at him, but took a strained breath to ensure she was capable. Anger was well and good, but if she asphyxiated she wouldn't be able to go help Vince once Shane left.

"Okay then, on to the next task." Shane walked over to Vince, careful to keep a healthy distance, then flipped him onto his back and pinned him down with the same branch acquiring technique he'd used on Camille. While his power was similar to Thomas's, the ability to strike from any area and to manipulate his shadows into bladed weapons made Shane a far more deadly opponent. Had he taken a different route, he could have been a world-class assassin. As it was, he spent much of his training learning ways to utilize his ability so it wouldn't be deadly. That was why his major was biology; it was why he studied anatomy in his free time. That was why he knew what muscles he could cut without causing a target to bleed out.

"There are a lot of stories about you, Vince," Shane said as he lowered the branch in place, making sure it rested heavily on but didn't crush his captive. Shane was careful to move around as he talked, changing direction frequently. Even injured and pinned, giving Vince a stationary target was asking for trouble. "How you stood your ground against Coach George, how you dominated Michael in the first match this year, and, of course, your neat trick against Thomas during last year's midterms. You're a strong guy, and I've trained with you in combat enough to know you've got hand-to-hand chops." Shane finished adjusting the branch and stood a few steps further back.

"That said, you need to understand the gap between those in the

middle and those at the top. Dean Blaine outlined it for us during the first year. Only the strongest can move on, because only we have a place in the Hero world. People depend on us, I know you know that. You're the kind of guy who fights all the harder when there are people who need him. I respect you for that."

"Thanks," Vince gasped from under the limb. "Didn't seem to help much."

"You've got a Hero's heart," Shane said. "You just don't have a Hero's strength. I've taken you out as painlessly as possible, much more gently than some of the people who don't share my sentiment would have. Just tell me who has your orb and I'll be on my way."

"No," Vince rasped. "I'm not telling you anything."

"Can't say I'm really surprised," Shane sighed. "You're the type that would let me peel off his skin before he said a word that might lead to his friends being hurt. I had to try, at least. I could probably get it out of you, but it would take far too long to be worth it. Oh well, I suppose taking out two of my rival team's most useful members will have to be good enough."

He moved quickly and carefully, being certain not to enter Vince's field of vision. Even in exiting Shane's motions were deliberate and thought out.

Vince tested the heft holding him down and found it unmoving. If he'd had both arms he might have been able to pull something out, but with his injuries there was no chance of conventional escape. His head thudded softly as it fell backward onto the grass. It felt strangely good to lay there, motionless, staring up at the false sky. Time was running out, and he needed to think of something.

It was either that or accept that this was his last day at Lander.

## 175.

Violet couldn't really fly. It would be more accurate to say she floated, decreasing her density until she was able to stay aloft on air currents. Upping her speed or changing direction was just a matter of increasing a small part of her body's density and casting it in the direction she wanted to travel. For example, she could punch to the left while making the nail on her index finger heavier for half of a second, resulting in her whole body being moved forcibly. This technique, while effective, was also very strange to see in action: Violet's navigation mimicked the jerking of an epileptic squid. That said, it worked.

Alice dashed to the side as Violet whooshed by, hand clutched into a fist that would have no doubt become much heavier right before impacting Alice. Violet kicked backwards and reversed trajectory, reorienting herself and coming around for another attack. So far Alice had managed to dodge effectively - she had more practice thinking in three-dimensions than her opponent - however, she also knew she was in very real trouble if Violet should manage to land a blow. She could increase the gravity around Violet, but that was difficult given the girl's constant movement. Not to mention that Alice didn't know how much of that force Violet could ignore by becoming less dense. The one thing she did know was that she was only going to have the element of surprise once, and then it was gone.

"You're quick," Violet said, pausing her formerly ceaseless barrage to catch her breath. "To be honest, I'm a little impressed. I thought you'd have tried to escape by now."

"Now why would I do that?"

"Because you don't have any way to win. Your power only lets you fly, and now that I've come into your world, it's just a matter of time before I catch you."

"I suppose it's just not in me to walk away from a fight."

"It most certainly is, and you're neither stupid nor overly prideful. So that means you think you've got a shot at winning this." Violet's smile was wide, showing too many teeth for it to be taken as a friendly gesture. "You've been sandbagging."

"I'd prefer to say that I just haven't had the chance to showcase my

talents,” Alice replied.

“Then consider this your opening night. There’s nothing I enjoy more than a good tussle, so bring it on. Let’s see what you can really do.”

This time it was Alice who surged forward, utilizing her superior speed and maneuverability to come down on Violet, dropping a fist directly toward her throat. She almost pulled it off; however, what Alice had in flying practice, Violet had in battle experience. She rolled to the side at the last moment, sending Alice’s punch into her shoulder. The blonde girl was momentarily thrown off kilter, and Violet used that opportunity to wrap both arms around her torso. As soon her grip was firm, Violet turned up her own density, sending them downward and dragging Alice out of the sky.

“Good effort,” Violet said as their pace began to increase. “A little quicker and you might have gotten me.”

“It isn’t over yet,” Alice snapped. “I’m betting this landing hurts you, too.” She focused on decreasing their gravity, slowing the descent as much as possible. She still had a plan, but it required Violet to be much denser.

“You’d be surprised how tough I am when I get heavy.” Violet was impressed the blonde could haul this much weight. She turned up her own ability, making herself even heavier. They began to fall faster, and Violet cranked it up even more. She would be sure to cushion Alice from the blow, but it should be enough to keep the girl grounded for some while.

Alice didn’t reply this time; her attention was on the approaching tree tops. She had to time this perfectly: otherwise Violet would just shift back again. Her mind grew empty as she focused on the gravity that enveloped them. Alice had already done more in practice than just excuse herself from its hold or turn up the knob on others: she’d also changed the very direction it pulled in. It hadn’t been easy, and she’d never tried something this delicate before. They passed the first tip of a tree and there was no more time for debate or doubt.

It was showtime.

Violet’s arms were ripped away from Alice’s body as an unseen force yanked them in opposite directions. At the same time, she felt her own rate of descent increase dramatically. This wasn’t just losing the counterforce of the flier: she was moving much too swiftly for that to be the case. As Alice bobbed overhead, a quickly shrinking point in Violet’s line of sight, it all came together.

“Gravity. You sandbagging bitch,” she muttered. The next sound was the tremendous crash of a college-aged girl whose weight was currently in the hundreds of tons smashing into the ground. It caved into a crater of impressive size, uprooting a few trees and sending who knows how many rocks flying. She’d have likely fallen much farther if not for the special material Lander’s walls, and more importantly floors, were made from.

A less dense item would have been damaged beyond repair. As it was, Violet felt like she’d gotten her bell rung pretty noticeably. It would take her a few minutes to shake it all off, but she wasn’t out of the fight yet. She looked up from her giant crater and saw Alice still floating above her. It was hard to see at such a distance, but Violet noticed the floating form seemed to be making motions with its arms. She had just enough time to wonder what on earth that girl was doing before she noticed the rumbling sound that was filling her ears.

Trees, rubble, and other sizable debris began careening over the lip of the crater, crashing down the slope to land at the lowest point, directly on top of Violet. Violet felt the burdens fall on top of her, not heavy enough to do any damage but certainly making her inevitable escape more difficult. She could lower her density enough to become insubstantial, but that meant a brief moment where she’d be normal and pinned under an ever-increasing mountain of crap. Her only other option was to weaken each hunk of debris piece by piece until she was able to get out.

Well, she had told Alice to bring it. Violet made a note to congratulate her friend when this was all said and done. Assuming she made it out before the start of summer vacation, of course.



Roy and Thomas had never squared off before, though they'd spent enough time in the same social circle that each was familiar with the other's abilities. At least, that's what Roy thought before their match began. He'd expected to be battling against energy tendrils or maybe some straight up blast attacks. What he hadn't expected was that Thomas might have been expanding his own repertoire since the match with Vince and Alex over a year ago.

The tree shattered as Roy was hurled through it, splinters tearing his uniform but failing to pierce his skin. Idly Roy wondered if he'd be holding up so well had this fight happened earlier in the year. He highly doubted it; right now the only thing keeping him conscious was the amount of damage he could take, and even that was beginning to reach its limits. He pulled himself up from the grassy ground and looked around, trying to locate his opponent. It didn't take long; the one drawback of Thomas's technique was that it made him easy to spot.

Thomas was walking toward Roy, ignoring any challenges the terrain might have presented to slow him down. It would be impossible to say what expression was draped across his face, since it, along with the rest of his body, was hidden beneath the orange energy that enveloped his entire form. It moved with him, surrounding and protecting the body beneath. Roy suspected he might be able to punch through it, but that would require getting up close and personal, a task at which he had thus far been highly unsuccessful.

Roy sprinted forward, closing the gap between him and Thomas as quickly as possible. He made it to within ten feet before a beam of energy leapt forth from Thomas's hand and enveloped his legs. The taller boy was swept off his feet and chunked into another poor tree, which exploded on impact. A quick hop to his feet and Roy was running again. They'd been playing this game for some time now, and it didn't seem like it would end any time soon. Still, Roy hadn't quite lost hope yet. The first time he'd only been able to get within fifteen feet of Thomas.

He was getting closer. Now he just had to close the gap before Thomas found a way to put him down for good.

\* \* \*

Alex grabbed the biggest thing near him - in this case a smoldering hunk of tree from Jill's last missed shot - and telekinetically tossed it in Selena's direction. The throw was wild; however, it landed near enough that she had to scramble to stay clear. That created a break in her song, which gave Alex a much needed moment of respite.

Sweat poured down his face and the beginnings of what would ultimately culminate in a hellacious headache were starting to manifest. A year ago he wouldn't have even been in this good of shape. Mary always envied Alex's level of control, but at the moment he was more thankful for his ability to multitask. Fending off Selena's song and Jill's blasters simultaneously was taking every bit of focus he could muster. He was managing not to go down; however, using all his resources for defense left him also no opportunity to counterattack. If he didn't think of something soon then it was just a matter of running down the clock to his inevitable defeat.

Jill fired off another few rounds, two of which Alex dodged and the other he deflected. Without his telepathy he might have been hosed: fighting back all the sound around him meant he didn't get any audible warnings of her movements. Only keeping tabs on her mind was giving him notice to defend. Even that strategy had a downside, because in this small of an area, listening to her mind meant feeling Selena's as well, something he'd been trying very hard not to do since their breakup.

There was no softness in that head of hers, no inclination to go easy on him in this battle for the sake of old emotions. Selena was a sophomore in the HCP; she never would have gotten this far if she couldn't divorce duty from sentiment. There wasn't any anger, either, something he'd honestly expected, despite the reason for breaking up. It wouldn't have been rational, but in Alex's experience, people very rarely were when the heart was involved. No, none of that was bouncing around in Selena's mind, likely because there was no room for it. Instead, her head was overflowing with love and regret.

He could feel it all: the depth of love she'd been surprised to find she had for him, the fear at something so serious so soon, the hasty rebellion to try and distance herself through a stupid drunken action, and the loss she'd been gripped with upon realizing what she'd destroyed. In a different time, in a different place, it might have motivated him to have a cup of coffee with her, to see if there was anything left for them to put back together. Unfortunately for both of them, this was not that time or that place. All Alex could feel at that moment was a wish that she would bottle her shit up so he could concentrate.

A flurry of excitement overtook Jill as she took aim for another volley. This time there were only two shots. One was far enough away to sidestep; the other would have to be deflected. He was about to grip it when he realized that only the first shot had been energy; the one heading toward him was a metal canister the size of half a soda can. Before Alex was able to react, the small canister exploded and his entire world went white.

It took a moment to realize he wasn't burned or harmed, but from the searing sensation in his eyeballs, it felt like he had been.

"Flash grenade Will designed. You should regain vision in five to ten minutes," Jill informed him helpfully.

Alex had just enough time to wonder how he was able to hear her then realized that his concentration had been disintegrated, along with his vision, before Selena's song took hold. He slumped to the ground wordlessly.

Selena ceased her singing and walked over to him. She took off his jacket, singed in a few places for shots Jill nearly landed, and folded it into a thick square. Delicately lifting his head, she tucked the makeshift pillow under his cranium before turning back to her teammate.

Julia came up to them during this time, one of many clones scattered with the teams. She had to keep away from the actual battle, since if she was seriously hurt she would dissipate and they would lose their connection to the rest of the team.

"Let's go find another one," Selena said, her face largely expressionless.

Jill nodded her agreement, and the three set off for their next battle.

“You orange glowing bastard!” Roy screamed as he went sailing through the air yet again. He’d lost count of his flights somewhere in the teens, not because it was too hard to keep up, but because there was no point. Each had thought one of them would break, run out of steam, or come up with a new strategy to end things. As it was, they were dancing the same tango they’d been shimmying since they started.

Thomas’s own sentiment wasn’t much more positive. By his assessments of Roy’s strength, Thomas should have prevailed by now, but the taller young man had gotten much stronger in a short time. When things were over, Thomas would ask him how he’d pulled that off. For the moment, he was simply trying to figure out a way to finish this pointless battle. The problem was that Roy had the advantage in his endless energy. Thomas was beginning to feel the first signs of fatigue, signs he knew his opponent would never suffer at this pace. He still had a lot of gas left in the tank, but that wouldn’t matter if he didn’t find a way to hurt Roy. At this pace the most he could hope for was a clean escape.

Thomas blinked beneath his orange armor as the realization hit him. Why not escape? This test wasn’t predicated on winning individual fights, only on who got the most points through orbs. He wasn’t helping his team right now; in fact, he was wasting himself as a resource. The beginnings of suspicion began to tickle in his brain. This was probably part of the exam: not only winning when it was possible, but also walking away when it wasn’t. It was what the second match had been meant to teach them. The more he thought about it, the more certain Thomas grew.

A snapping of branches alerted Thomas that Roy was charging again. He enveloped his opponent’s legs in energy, just as he had countless times before. This time was different. Instead of chunking Roy at the nearest object, Thomas put more power into the throw and aimed higher. He cast Roy with all of his might, sending him sailing over the tree line far from their current position. By the time Roy found his way back, Thomas would be long gone.

Distantly, almost imperceptibly, Roy’s voice could be heard screaming obscenities as he flew through the air.

“Results are in,” Mary whispered. She was reasonably certain she and Nick were alone, but the way things were going, she wasn’t up for taking any risks. “One win, two losses, and a draw.”

“How did we get a draw? Wait, never mind, let me guess. Thomas and Roy?”

“Nailed it. Thomas realized he was wasting his time, so he headed off to find a better fight. Roy is less than thrilled.”

“I can imagine.”

“Anyway, Alex lost, so did Camille and Vince. Alice, thankfully, pulled her match off rather impressively,” Mary reported.

In spite of the bad news, Nick allowed himself a small smile at news of Alice’s victory. The girl deserved a win, and putting one up against an opponent like Violet was no small matter. As honest as his joy was, it was equally brief. Immediately his brain began assessing the news of the losses and adjusting his plan.

“How are they holding up?”

“Alex is knocked out, Camille is largely unhurt but stuck under a tree branch. Vince is pinned, too, but he’s been torn up pretty bad.”

“Shane separated and trapped them so Camille couldn’t heal Vince. Smart guy. I hate other smart guys.”

“Should we go help them?”

Nick shook his head. He’d suspected this might happen, not just when he heard they were facing Shane, but from the very beginning. Vince had gotten so much stronger than he’d been even a few months ago, but it wasn’t as if he were going up against mere humans. Everyone else was growing too, getting better at what they did. Vince might one day be the strongest of them all; however, that day wasn’t this one. And if he didn’t find a way to showcase Vince’s real potential then that day might very well never come. The only guidance he had was Globe’s advice, about the fact that they were all underestimating Vince’s real power and how kindness was both the cage and the key. Understanding it hadn’t been difficult, but discerning a good way to utilize it had left Nick with precious few options.

“Okay, Mary, here’s the plan. First things first, I’m calling in the twenty-four hours of non-mental listening you owe me.”

“What?”

“Freshman year, I did you a favor by taking Alice shopping, and that was my price. I’m calling it in, effective immediately. Do not, under any circumstances, listen to my thoughts for the rest of this day.”

“Can I ask why?”

“You can ask anything, you just won’t get answers. Next, I need you to tell me where Rich is, currently.” As he spoke, Nick reached up and removed his sunglasses. He carefully applied pressure to one of the lenses until it snapped, leaving a slightly jagged edge.

“About fifteen minutes to our east,” Mary replied, pointing despite the fact that she was certain Nick knew the direction in question.

“Perfect. Now, keep hunting our invisible girl, but if you haven’t found her in thirty minutes then refocus on making sure Alex and Alice get to the deposit site before the timer ends. Stay out of sight until I get there.” Nick took the jagged edge of plastic and used it to cut a section of his uniform’s coat, then ripped along the tear until he had a long, if ragged, piece of grey cloth.

“They’ll make you pay for that, you know,” Mary pointed out, having honestly no idea what else to say to his strange behavior.

“I’m aware of the rules.”

“Are you sure I shouldn’t go help Vince and Camille instead of hunting Britney? What if they don’t get free in time?”

“Vince will get them free,” Nick replied simply. “Trust me.”

“I guess at this point I pretty much have to.”

“And words cannot say how much I appreciate it.” Nick was finished making his cloth strip, so he tucked it into his right pocket. He put the jagged plastic in his left and let the remains fall to the ground. He didn’t need them any longer.

Nick looked at Mary; she was staring up at him with a perplexed annoyance. She was true to her word: if she’d been listening to his thoughts, she would have worn a very different expression. Good; he’d have hated for her to get caught up in this. When the dust settled she was going to need to be able to honestly say she had no idea what he was planning. Ignorance was the

only protection he could give her.

“So, while I’m doing all this running around, what are you going to do?”

“Very simple, my dear Captain,” Nick replied. “I’m going to build a pyre.”

## 178.

Vince lost consciousness for a few minutes after Shane left. It might have been the blood loss, though Shane had been careful not to leave wounds that risked bleeding out. It might have been the sizable branch weighing on his torso, but it was not so heavy as to leave him unable to breathe. It might have even been shame. After all that training, all that discussion and planning and bravado, he'd still been trounced like he was nothing. He was supposed to be a force that his team could rely on. Instead it seemed like he spent most of time lying on the ground, defeated.

"Are you all right?" Camille asked, raising her voice slightly to be heard. It risked them being discovered, but that didn't matter much at the moment. It didn't make any student look more skilled to beat up defeated opponents. No, the worst they could suffer upon discovery was humiliation, and that was low on her list of current concerns.

"I'm stuck, but I think I've stopped bleeding," Vince answered. There was no more sensation of warm, sticky blood tickling down his appendages. The muscles were still cut; nothing short of Camille was going to fix that.

"Don't move too much, you don't want to reopen your cuts. I'll heal you as soon as this is over and we get free."

And there it was. They had to sit and wait; they were out of the match. Camille was too weak to lift her branch, and even if Vince had been at full strength, he doubted he could have budged his. He tested his appendages and found them largely unresponsive. He could move them, but with the severed tendons it was painful and hard to direct them. Lifting was out of the question; the only thing he could get to move in even a semblance of control was his left arm. He flopped it against the branch and felt the rough bark press against his palm.

"Damn it, what did I just tell you?"

"Sorry, I... I think I have an idea." He couldn't push it away, and using a kinetic blast was too dangerous. Aiming was impossible, so the branch might easily land on Camille. He did have another option. One that would be uncomfortable, one that was risky, one that was certain to hurt. Still, it would get him a chance to get back in the game. He'd promised Nick the team could count on him. And... to be perfectly honest, he knew that if he failed here, it



was over. No third year, no hopes of being a Hero. Once he was ousted, they would never let the son of Globe back in. He either got back up, or he may as well go back to sleep and accept these two years for the dream they were.

“Camille, you might want to look away.”

“What are you going to do?”

But Vince had already done it. Fire burst forth from his left hand, a surge of flame cascading across the branch’s surface. His own flame didn’t hurt him as it exited, but as the branch began to burn in earnest, he noticed the temperature rising. Immediately he began to sweat, the heat so close and so forceful that it was all he could do not to pull it back. Not yet.

“Vince!”

He could hear the panic in Camille’s voice; he wished she’d listened to him and looked away. His uniform was on fire, the flames were beginning to lick against his skin. Vince had imagined all the severed muscles would restrict his ability to feel pain. Either he was wrong, or the pain was so great it didn’t matter. He set his jaw and resisted the urge to scream. This had to be hard enough for his teammate to watch; he wouldn’t let her know how badly he was hurting. He’d been burned before; he knew what was still in store for him.

The smoke was getting overpowering; it was growing steadily harder to breath. Good. Only a little bit longer. He needed to be certain the tree was burning on its own. He couldn’t hear Camille’s words anymore, but he could definitely hear her yelling at him. The fire was too loud, or he was too close. God he wished she’d looked away. Vince glanced down and realized that his left hand was turning charred and black; the proximity to the fire had burned away all the nerves before he’d noticed it. His vision was getting blurry. Time was up, now or never. He could only pray it had been long enough.

Vince absorbed the fire in an instant, the branch dissolving into ash as he took both its current energy and all the energy it would have generated as it burned. His jacket was taken too. Mercifully his pants hadn’t caught fire in time to be absorbed. He saw that his torso was sooty and black. At least he hoped that was soot.

“What is wrong with you? Why would you do that?” Camille wasn’t yelling anymore; from the rasp in her voice it sounded like she’d screamed herself hoarse. Her cheeks were wet, glistening with tears that still flowed freely from her eyes. Poor girl. Vince would apologize afterward. He couldn’t

respond yet; he needed all his focus for the last part.

Carefully he rolled onto his side, aiming as best he could. He pressed his ruined hand onto the charred ground that had once been grass. He owed a thank you to Nick for forcing him to gain some semblance of control of this new aspect to his powers, and to Roy for charging him up. With a grunt of effort he blasted the solid ground with kinetic energy, sending him hurtling across the grass and leaving a trail of partially cooked flesh where it scraped against him. He nearly passed out again, this time unquestionably from pain, but he fought back the sensation of slumber and rolled himself over. He was close to Camille now, almost in arm's reach. With one last burst of effort, Vince rolled over once, twice, three more times. The third was the last he had in him: as his vision turned skyward the screaming pain finally overwhelmed his willpower and he fell into the blissful darkness.

"You fucking idiot." A pair of dainty hands fell on his forehead, the only part of him she could reach. Camille choked back a sob as she looked at him. He was a wreck; he was destroyed. He'd gotten to her at the cost of god only knew how much pain. She began healing the burns first, watching his skin turn back to its normal pink hue. Then she healed the muscles and finally the cuts Shane had left on his body.

It took only a moment and his eyes fluttered open. He pulled himself upright and gave his body a quick once over. Satisfied he was healthy, he turned to Camille.

"Thank you, yet again," he said with a smile.

He pushed his restored hand under her branch then blasted it away with a kinetic burst. Since he was able to aim, there was no fear it would come down on her like his branch might have. It crashed into a tree and shattered into little more than splinters. Camille pulled herself up, ignoring his outstretched hand. She took a brief moment to heal her own injuries and wipe her face, then she turned to face him.

Had he known it was coming, Vince probably could have dodged her punch. As it was, it struck him squarely in the jaw, leaving him with watering eyes of his own.

"Fuck you! Fuck you for doing that! Fuck you taking that risk! Fuck you for... FUCK YOU!" Camille was shaking and her face was red, but for once it had nothing to do with embarrassment. "You could have died, you idiot. If you'd passed out from pain or smoke inhalation you could have

burned to death under that branch. Did you even think of that? I can't heal the dead, you goddamned pigheaded moron. We'd have been fine, we'd have survived."

"I would have been eliminated," Vince said softly, avoiding her eyes. "If I don't give them some reason to keep me, if I go down again, I won't come back next year."

This time Vince did see it coming, but he purposely didn't avoid it. Camille slapped him on the cheek with all her might, adding to the already noticeable pain in his jaw.

"So what! You'd have moved on. There is life after Lander. But you can't help anyone if you die. You can't be there for the people you care about in any capacity, Hero or otherwise. Did you think about that? Did you really consider the consequences for everyone else while selfishly risking your life for some stupid job? Life doesn't end if you get kicked out. Life definitely ends if you burn yourself to death in some dumbass escape attempt. The next time you do anything like that, I'm not going to heal you. I'll pull you back from death, but then I'll leave you to suffer."

Her shaking was getting worse. Vince reached his arms around her and pulled her in close. It wasn't a conscious decision: in that moment it was merely what he knew she needed him to do. She struggled briefly then allowed him to hold her until the shivering subsided.

"I won't help you kill yourself," she whispered into his chest.

"I'll be more careful," Vince told her. "I promise."

She stayed in his arms for a few moments more then pulled away. "What's done is done. We should get moving. We made a lot of noise."

Vince nodded wordlessly and they set off back into the battle. Camille made no offer to heal the blows she'd dealt, and he didn't dream of asking for it.

Rich might have heard his assailant coming if he hadn't been distracted by Julia's clone talking. He might have seen him if his gaze hadn't been drawn by smoke rising to the north. He might have still had a shot if he'd gotten that prickling sensation of being watched before the taser sent its searing voltage into his back. None of those things happened, which only goes to show that a power which can merely affect probability still has its uses. By the time Rich recovered, he realized his hands had been bound behind his back and a thick strip of cloth was tied against his head, covering his eyes.

"Julia! Call for help!"

"So sorry, your energy clone has been disconnected. Please pick up a fresh one and try again later."

Rich felt the tension he hadn't noticed in his shoulders loosen. Being captured was bad. Having his eyes covered was worse. But if he was only caught by Nick, then he didn't have much to worry about. The guy had caught a few lucky breaks, obviously, but he was nothing to get worked up over.

"Did you shock her too?"

"Cracked her over the head with a branch. I'm afraid she's completely dissipated already." Nick's voice was coming from behind Rich, and it was calm. Actually, this was the first time Rich remembered Nick not coming off as flippant, joking, or sarcastic in some manner.

"That was stupid. If it had been the real one you might have gotten disqualified, not to mention seriously hurt her."

"A calculated risk. I needed access to you, and I couldn't risk her relaying to the others what was about to happen."

"You leaving me captured and useless?" The tension was creeping back into Rich. Something wasn't right. Ambushing him might have been Nick's style, but the rest of this, the careful bindings, the ruthless dispatching of Julia's clone, it didn't sit right.

Nick laughed, and something in Rich's stomach turned. "I'm not leaving you anywhere. You're going to be a very helpful part in making sure my team wins."

Rich snorted and felt Nick draw closer. Nick leaned in closely, his mouth less than an inch from Rich's ear. Briefly he contemplated a head butt; however, he doubted Nick was as open as he seemed. This was all too calculated for him to make an error like that.

"I don't want anyone to overhear this part," Nick whispered, his breath hot on Rich's ear. "It also wouldn't do for them to read my lips later from some hidden camera's video, so forgive the proximity. When they ask you about this later, you should tell them this is where I threatened to kill you."

Rich gulped, not because he thought Nick was actually making that threat, but because some part of him understood he wouldn't be telling him to lie if he wasn't about to threaten something worse.

"In fact, this is where I tell you that I also employ a hidden camera or two from time to time. Like that time before winter break where I paid you and Adam to come incapacitate and then impersonate Vince to take his test for him."

"But-" Rich's next words never left his mouth; they were superseded by a cry of pain as Nick reached down and pulled back his pinky until it snapped.

"Your mouth isn't covered. You don't get to talk. Sorry about that, but at least that will make this look real."

Rich whimpered softly, but otherwise took the cue and remained silent.

"Now then, I'm sure you were going to say that if I really did have that tape, then turning it in would get both Adam and me in trouble, too. You're certainly correct there; however, you're also operating under the delusion that I give two fucks about staying here. In that regard, you are woefully wrong. So here is what is going to happen. You will stand up and loudly protest that you're not telling me where the orb is. That will keep the professors from intervening when they notice I've taken you prisoner. If you try and yell about me threatening your life right now, then they'll save you. And then I'll show them you committing extreme academic fraud for money, all but guaranteeing the end of your career as a Hero. If you play along, on the other hand, I promise to give you that video file and make sure you come out blameless when the dust settles. Your choice."

Rich felt himself being pulled up, and while the force was rough, there

was evidently care to make sure he got his footing and didn't fall down. A sharp pain came from the broken finger in his hand. This was insane; this couldn't really be happening. He was a Super, a skilled warrior. He couldn't have been taken prisoner, have been made utterly useless so easily. And by Nick of all people! But... the scam to help Vince had been smart. The more Rich thought about it, the more it started making sense. Despite his demeanor, didn't Nick always seem to come out ahead? Everyone had brushed it off as luck, but maybe...

Nick cleared his throat and brushed Rich's broken finger, sending more pain through it. He was supposed to deliver the line about the orb: that was Nick reminding him. He could still call for help. The professors would let a certain amount slide, this was a brutal game by its nature, however this had to be more than they'd tolerate. He could get free, but if Nick was telling the truth, his career as a Hero would be destroyed. So it came down to whether or not he thought Nick was so cunning a person that he would record his own illicit activities in case he needed to blackmail his compatriots later. Rich didn't think he was. Of course, he also didn't think Nick was the type to do any of the things that had passed in the last five minutes. So, was he willing to risk it?

"Let me go, damn it! I'm not telling you who has the orb!"

"Fine then; I'm still keeping you with me to make sure you don't get free," Nick replied loudly. Rich could imagine the smug look on his face, and to his credit, he got it almost exactly right. The part he missed he can hardly be blamed for: only a select few people knew that Nick's eyes glowed with golden light when he used his power.

Right now, resting atop that calculated smug expression, they blazed like a pair of twin suns.

## 180.

Alice was surprised to see a rock floating up to her, given her location in the air and the general lack of buoyancy associated with dense minerals. Then she realized someone had etched “Follow Me” across the flat front of it and grew suspicious. This looked like Mary’s doing, but it could be a trap. Violet could have made a rock light enough to get up here, but she couldn’t have made it guide her back to an ambush. Agatha could make inanimate objects move; however she was unable to change their properties. Alice was reasonably sure Tiffani’s illusions didn’t have this good a range, but just to be sure, she poked the stone with her finger. It wasn’t a high-minded or fancy test, but the stone was solid, so she knew it was real.

That left the combination of Will and Jill, who might have made this using some crazy technology. Alice was reasonably certain she could get the drop on them if it was. Besides, this was a weirdly specific gizmo to have up their sleeves. At last she realized the easiest way to get confirmation. She thought about how if it were really Mary sending this, it should start doing loop the loops. Sure enough, the stone began floating in tight circles through the sky. That was as good as Alice was going to get, so she thought about how she was ready to follow it, then floated after as it began to descend.

The stone drifted down to Mary, who was waiting in a small clearing just large enough for Alice to land in safely.

“Find Britney?”

“Sadly, no. She used Gilbert to hop about periodically, making tracking her all but impossible. I managed to avoid everyone and hang onto our orb, at least.”

“That’s something. So why the rock?” Alice’s feet settled gently on the ground using a controlled maneuver that the Powered version of her could never have imagined.

“I need to round up as many of us as possible. We’re supposed to meet at the depository before it goes active,” Mary explained.

“Are we laying an ambush?”

“Honestly? I have no idea what we’re doing,” Mary sighed. “We’ve got enough time to grab Roy on the way, so we should get moving. Alex

woke up a little while ago; he got the message from me and is already on his way.”

“What about Nick?”

“No idea where he is or what he’s doing. I owed him a day of not listening to his thoughts from a favor last year, and he called it in during this match. He’s the one who wants us to meet with him, so I feel safe assuming he has something planned.”

“Nick always has something planned. It’s just not always something we should want to go along with.”

“Vince and Camille lost to Shane, Alex lost to Selena and Jill,” Mary informed her. “You’re the only winner; the rest of us have been safe or gotten a draw. No one has stolen an orb yet, so right now we’re all getting evaluated on our performances in this match.”

“Some of us might make it,” Alice said, though she didn’t know which of them she was trying to comfort.

“Some of us. Might,” Mary replied.

“Damn it. So we either resolve ourselves to losing some friends or we go with Nick’s plan, whatever it might be.”

“Or we try to make a grand last stand at the depository,” Mary countered. “However, I’m pretty sure Nick is already thinking of something along those lines anyway.”

“Funny, he’s not really the ‘go out in a blaze of glory’ type,” Alice mused. “I say we go along for now. Time has to be getting close, so we’d need to go anyway. We can always tell him no if we don’t like his idea.”

Mary nodded and the two set off, but inwardly she wondered about such a notion. She’d been deeper in Nick’s head than anyone else; she appreciated the extent to which he planned, the lengths that he was capable of going to in order to reach success. She had a nagging feeling that by the time they knew what Nick’s plan was, it would already be too late to do anything but watch.

\* \* \*

“This isn’t looking good,” Professor Pendleton muttered as they watched the various students fight, sneak, or trudge across an expansive



display of monitors. He kept his voice low, audible only to Dean Blaine, who stood next to him. Behind them was a room half-full of people. Most were the other professors and staff; however, a few were people dressed exceedingly professionally. Two of them were board members, and one, an older man whose hair was just beginning to grey, was their guest. He'd showed no badge, offered no job title; he'd merely been quiet and watched the students on the monitor. Or, rather, one student. His sunken eyes had never wavered from whatever monitor was currently displaying Vince Reynolds.

"The thing with the branch was impressive," Dean Blaine replied.

"Would have been more impressive if coupled with a win," Professor Pendleton shot back.

"Shane is second only to Chad among the males. That would have been the result against nearly any other student."

"Too bad it was against Vince."

"Agreed." Dean Blaine kept his sympathy for the silver-haired boy off his face and out of his voice. Right now he did his student more good by seeming objective, whatever little difference it might ultimately make.

"They're heading for the depository. Think they've got any shot of pulling this one out of the crapper?"

"My answer depends largely on your thoughts about something. On monitor seventeen you've surely noticed Nick Campbell leading a captured Rich Weaver toward the same place as the others. He's avoided detection so far, and the audio indicated he took Rich prisoner to keep him from getting back into play." Dean Blaine hesitated, checking to be certain they weren't currently being overheard. At least he didn't have to fear telepaths or super-hearing; thank heaven for small favors. "Do you believe that is actually what he's doing?"

"Not a chance. That's a stupid plan. The kid might be a lot of things, but he isn't one to use stupid plans."

The lightest twitch of a smile played at the corner of Dean Blaine's mouth.

"Then I suspect this show has not yet reached the final act."

Vince and Camille didn't talk much as they moved through the arena. They'd run into Alex, who had told them of the need to move toward to the depository; however, after that brief discussion they'd lapsed back into silence. One could make the argument that this was out of necessity, since they were sneaking across terrain where enemies could come from any direction. That theory wasn't wrong, not entirely, but it failed to capture the true awkwardness of the silence that had descended upon them.

Vince turned at every noise, halting their progress. He was on alert, beginning to verge on paranoid, determined not to be taken by surprise again. It might not have made a difference against Shane, but that didn't mean it wouldn't make a difference against the next opponent. He was out of second chances. If he screwed up again then failure was inevitable.

The two crept past a thick patch of bushes, walking into a clearing they hadn't expected to be there. Waiting for them was a pair of figures, quite possibly the last coupling they'd expected to see.

"Nick?" Vince pulled himself to a standing position. His dorm mate smiled back at him, but it wasn't the smile Vince was used to seeing. There was something different about him, something far more disconcerting than the glowing eyes.

"Just in time," Nick said, jerking his prisoner to his feet. "By my count we have less than twenty minutes until the depository becomes active."

"Why did you tie up Rich?" Vince asked. He heard Camille walk into the clearing behind him, then felt her tense up unexpectedly. This was their friend, so why were both of them getting such a sense of danger from the situation?

"For what it's worth, Vince, I didn't want to do it this way. I sincerely hoped you'd be able to pull things off on your own. Unfortunately, sometimes even the purest of intentions need a little help from people on my side." Nick made a quick motion with his hand, one so subtle Vince barely noticed it.

Vince opened his mouth to ask for more clarity then saw a more attention-catching movement: a flutter of grey cloth floating to the ground. He glanced at it, only for a second, but a pair of eyes was waiting to meet his, and then it was over.

Nick snatched the cloth from the air as Vince froze, securing it once more around Rich's eyes in a manner of moments.

"You gave him exactly what I told you to, right?"

"I included the entire framework. His own mind has to supply the details," Rich answered, his voice strained. "For now, he'll follow basic direction. Once I look into his eyes again, his subconscious will start the scenario and he'll begin moving on his own."

"That gift of yours never ceases to amaze me."

"Nick," Camille said hesitantly, noticing the way Vince had frozen in place. "What did you do?"

"I made a bet against long odds," he replied simply. "Come on, we need to get moving. The rest of the teams will be gathering around the depository soon."

"I would really like to know what you've done," Camille was working hard to keep calm, but after her day so far she could hardly be blamed for a bit of worry.

"You'll know soon enough," Nick said, moving Rich toward the clearing's edge. "Everyone will know quite a bit, in fact." His prisoner set for movement, Nick walked back over to Vince, who was unmoved from the spot he'd been standing.

Nick patted his frozen friend on the shoulder. "I suppose we should get you in position. I know you can hear me right now, although I have no idea if you'll remember any of this. If so, I just wanted to take the opportunity to tell you that you've been a great friend, and I'll do all I can to watch over you out there."

"Nick, seriously, you are freaking me out," Camille said.

"Babe, you aren't nearly as freaked as you should be," Rich muttered under his breath.

"That's enough," Nick snapped. "Complain afterwards. Right now, it's time for action."

\* \* \*

Roy, Alice, Mary, and a somewhat downtrodden Alex huddled together near the edge of the tree line that faced the depository. The bright

beam of red light surged from a metallic box in the center of a clearing all the way up to the ceiling. Mary could hear the thoughts of others drawing near, hiding themselves amongst the trees until some signal was given. It would be a mad dash for the box. Theoretically someone could easily go stand atop it now, but giving away one's position would be suicide. Too many of their classmates had ranged abilities, and until an orb was deposited, it could still be stolen.

Mary heard the thoughts of an impending trio and prepared to get everyone in defensive formation, then realized there was no need. Nick, Camille, and a blindfolded Rich reached them a few minutes later, all but Nick looking some manner of peeved or disheveled.

"Where's Vince?" Alex whispered. Theoretically no one was close enough to hear them, but with Amber in the mix, it was always better to play it safe.

"He ran off," Camille whispered back. "Nick made Rich put some vision on him and he went darting off."

"Rich's visions immobilize people," Alice reminded her.

"Only if he wants them to," Nick corrected. His own tone was as loud as usual; he made no attempts to lower it. His eyes had dimmed as he appeared, going almost back to their normal boring color of brown. Finding the group had taken some luck, as had locating Rich and running into Vince. So far his luck had panned out, giving him the outcomes he was hoping for. There was still one last task to complete, and he was going to need every scrap of energy he had to pull it off.

"Okay, so where did you send Vince?" Mary asked, her tone curt. She was clearly getting tired of not knowing what was going on.

"Um, I think I can answer that one," Roy said, pointing past a thick trunk they were using to stay hidden. The others followed the direction of his finger, and what met their gaze was not a sight any of them would have hoped to see.

Standing next to the depository, in full view of all the opponents watching and waiting, was Vince Reynolds. He should have been bracing for attack, instead he was staring down at the metal box as though it held the secret to eternal life.

"Nick, you had better come up with a real good explanation, and I

mean now,” Mary threatened.

“I would, if only there were time. I’m afraid we should get moving. The show is about to start.”

## 182.

She was beyond bloody. Cuts ran across her fair skin, savage rips in her flesh that had been made by tooth and claw rather than something as precise as a scalpel. There was blood. There was so much blood. Vince wouldn't have believed anyone could be alive after losing so much, but she was still moving, motioning him towards her as words desperately tried to escape her damaged throat. He moved in slowly, carefully brushing aside a tangle of dark curls. A few strands of pale blonde hair fell away. When he remembered this discontinuity, it would cause him many nights of sleeplessness as he tried to puzzle out its meaning. That would come later; right now, there was only her.

Her... and the wretched sound of growling from the shadows that surrounded them.

\* \* \*

Team One rushed forward, they could already see some of their competitors edging into the clearing. If Vince registered movement from any source, it didn't show on his face. His eyes were laser-focused on the depository, his lips moving slightly, as if he were engaged in a conversation with the metal box.

"What the hell did you do to him?" Mary asked yet again as they sprinted.

"The long and short of it is, I freed him," Nick replied. He would have been slowed by having to lug along Rich, but thankfully Roy pitched in and helped heft the prisoner as they ran. "He won't see any of us as human; he won't even register what's going on. He sees the box as something he'll want to protect with his life, and he'll see anyone coming toward it as something intent on harming it. Well, except us. He should register us as allies."

"So, do you know what it is he's seeing the box as?" Camille asked, using all the subtlety as she could, which was clearly very little.

"Rich only conjures concepts. Vince's mind will fill in the details. It's more effective that way than if we tried to guess what would get his motor running."

"Right, and why exactly is Rich helping us again?" Roy asked.

“I’m a powerful motivator.”

“Cryptic as that is, I don’t see the point in any of this,” Alice said, able to speak more easily since she was coasting through the air rather than dashing across the ground. “Why go to all the trouble? We could have tried to stop people from depositing their orbs without brain-jacking Vince.”

Nick and Mary exchanged a quick glance. They hadn’t told the others about her talk with Globe, and now sure as hell wasn’t the time to bring it up. Mary nodded, almost imperceptibly, and Nick took the cue.

“Call it a hunch. It’s no secret that Vince’s recently uncovered parental origin put him at risk to be cut from this program.” That actually came as a surprise to several members of the team; however, they stayed silent and allowed Nick to continue. “Vince’s biggest weakness has always been himself. His goodness. He’s afraid of hurting his opponents, so he holds back. Sometimes it’s on purpose, sometimes it’s unconsciously. Either way, he can’t afford it this time. If Vince is ever going to show those people watching how strong he really is, then this is the moment for it. All I did was try and set up a scenario with the greatest chance of him doing that.”

“Still seems like a lot of effort for a minimal change,” Alice remarked.

“Wait until you see the change before you assess how minimal it is,” Nick replied.

“I’m on board,” Roy said. “So do we go over and help?”

“No. Vince needs to hold the line up there by himself. What we need to do is hold back as many as we can so they don’t converge and overwhelm him,” Nick explained. “Alice will lay down gravity fields to pin the weaker or dumber ones. Roy, you bat cleanup and knock away what you’re able to. Alex and Mary will try and make sure none of the long-range people are able to land a shot on him. Camille will stay with me since I’m largely helpless and will be lugging along a hostage. As for my job, I’ll be laying down as much luck as I can to give him an edge.”

“If we do all of that then won’t we be stopping the others before they can get to Vince?” Roy pointed out.

“Not possible,” Mary told him. “There are too many opponents with too much strength. At best we can slow some of them down. The truly strong ones will get through regardless.”

“Precisely,” Nick agreed. That was, in truth, a calculated piece of his plan. Vince needed to show off, and he needed to do it against students with high rankings for it to matter. There was also another reason Nick only wanted the strongest of their class to make it to Vince. Nick had a very high opinion of what Vince could do when letting loose, yet Globe had specifically said that none of them had the true measure of Vince’s power. That had been a message for Nick, telling him that his estimates were off. He didn’t know that he quite believed the mysterious villain, but it would be folly to not take into account the possibility that he was right. That was the real reason Nick wanted to keep the weaker students away from Vince.

Because, if Globe was right, there was a very real risk that Vince might kill someone.

Nick was snapped out of his reverie by the sound of a loud horn being broadcast through the arena. All at once, the red light that had been shining down on the depository turned blue. The five minutes window had started. Game on.

\* \* \*

“Vince...”

Her voice was a rasp, a whisper on the winds of impending death. She was so broken, so bloody, yet she reached up and carefully took his hand in her own. Her fingers were slick with blood, all of it her own.

“Vince... they’re coming back for me. Get away. Run.”

Something in his stomach twisted. A cold sensation he’d felt only once before began to seep through his brain. The world started dissolving. All his uncertainties, all his fears, all his concerns melted away from thought. All that remained was the girl. The girl, and the monsters that had done this to her.

From all around a hideous belting sound filled the air. The beasts in the shadows clacked their jaws together in hunger. Vince didn’t know what they were saying, but he understood that the sound had been a signal.

She pawed at him desperately. “They’re... coming.”

She was right; he could already hear their movements. They were drawing closer, but there was still some distance to cover. That was good. That gave him space to work in.



Vince leaned in and tenderly kissed her forehead, his mouth filling with the taste of copper.

“Don’t be afraid. I’ll protect you. I promise.”

He rose and faced the wall of shadows, out of which the twisted creatures had begun to emerge. They were coming all right, and coming fast. That was fine with Vince. Let them come. Let the bastards who had done this make the mistake of drawing close to him. He reached down within himself and felt the energy stored there.

Let them come. Vince was ready to show them what a true monster was.

## 183.

The explosion-like sound surprised all of the students, even those who had possessed some inkling of the hallucination occurring in Vince's brain. In one moment he had been calmly muttering to a steel box, the top of which had twisted open at the sound of the horn. He'd risen slowly and purposefully taken several strides forward. His breathing was even, his eyes were focused, his body was taut with anticipation. It was evident he was calmly awaiting any challengers.

Then came the blast, a tremendous sound that was in fact a thunderclap from the bolt of electricity Vince hurled into the tree line where some of the students were emerging. That smoking ruin was less eye-catching than Vince himself - at least the Vince they could see once their eyes adjusted to sudden increase in light. Vince, or Vince as they knew him, was gone. In his place stood a wraith of fire, a human shape exuding continuous flames from his body. Columns of fire lanced the ground in front of him, creating a charred and burning landscape that would be treacherous even for most of these Supers to cross. Electricity crackled at his fingertips, dancing along his digits in a malicious foxtrot of anticipation. For most that was all they saw. For a poor few with gifts of vision, they were able to catch a glimpse of more. They could pierce the flames and see the face of the young man working to burn the world, and what lay on his visage was nothing that gave them comfort. Vince was not regretful, nor worried, nor fearful of what was to come.

Vince was eager. Furiously eager. He couldn't wait for them to come closer. The fire was only the beginning. He wanted to show them the rest.

\* \* \*

"Sweet fucking Christ," Roy cursed, ducking instinctively at the loud sound and sudden burst of flame.

"I think that's our cue," Nick said, his eyes darting through the field of competitors to gauge their reactions. Most were surprised, some were afraid. A few were stalwart, but cautious. Nick noted the last group particularly. In the end that information wouldn't make a large difference, but it might make a small one. "You all know what to do."

"Kick ass until the bell sounds or we're all knocked out," Roy

surmised, pulling himself back up and dashing off toward a cluster of opponents still recovering their wits.

“I do love his enthusiasm,” Nick remarked.

“He does have spunk,” Alex concurred. He and Mary darted toward Vince; they needed to be close enough to deflect things hurled at him while staying far enough away to avoid his sweeping flame attacks.

“Nick, is this really going to work?” Alice floated a few feet from him, almost close enough to touch. He took his time answering her, pretending to be mulling it over. In truth he already knew what he would say; he was taking this time to stare unabashedly at his blonde dorm mate. She was truly beautiful: he could finally admit that to himself. It wasn’t just the golden hair, the stunning body, or the wide blue-eyes. It was her tenacity. Alice had turned from a spoiled princess into a determined warrior, and she’d done it mostly through her own gumption and relentlessness. He admired that. He adored that.

He was going to miss that.

“It will work,” he assured her at last. “At least, if we all do our best, it has a hell of a good shot. That’s all any of us can really hope for.”

Alice nodded her understanding. “I’ll try to keep my gravity fields off you, but I can’t make promises when dealing with this many people in this big of an area. Watch the grass; if it’s bending back on itself, stay clear of that area.” With that, she rose into the air and darted toward the center of the clearing. She would be a sitting duck, but Nick had a feeling most of the people who could bring her down would have their attention focused on Vince.

“Nice speech,” Camille said. They were alone now, save for Rich, who seemed to have decided long ago that silence was his ally in this precarious situation.

“Thank you.”

“One thing I can’t help but notice: you’ve put Vince in a situation where he is using lethal force without hesitation. Don’t you think that might put a damper on his chances of advancing, seeing as it’s an immediate disqualification?”

“It certainly would, were he doing it by choice. But when a man stabs

someone, you don't arrest the knife. That would be senseless. No, all the blame here lies not on the instrument of force, but on the man wielding it."

"I reached the same conclusion," Camille admitted softly. "You know, you're a pretty terrible person."

"You're not the first to accuse me of such."

"I didn't imagine I would be. Still, in spite of that, or maybe because of it, you're also a really good friend."

"On that account," Nick sighed, "I am nearly certain you are the first to utter such words. Now shush, the other teams have nearly reached our defenders. Once they do, we'll be in for one heck of a show."

\* \* \*

The observation room, previously filled only with softly whispered comments and observations, was now erupting into a din of noise as the situation below unfolded. Dean Blaine kept his cool; he had seen situations far worse than this one during his long career as a Hero and educator. That said, he also recognized the beginnings of first-class shitstorm when he saw them.

"That boy really put his dick in the beehive now," muttered Professor Cole from under her cloth wraps. Dean Blaine was inclined to agree, however he kept that particular thought to himself.

"Now, everyone, please settle down. We're all experienced combatants here; the concept of 'shock and awe' is not one that should be new to any of us. What Mr. Reynolds is doing, while unexpected, is a perfectly acceptable tactic in trying to drive off enemy forces."

"And what are we going to do if it escalates beyond just a show?" Professor Hill asked.

"We're going to keep the students safe, as we always have," Dean Blaine replied. "In order to do that we need to keep a close watch on them, however. So I would appreciate it if we could cut the chatter and keep focused on the matter at hand."

With that, the assembled individuals turned their attention back to the screens.

The sight that greeted them was pure chaos.



## 184.

Many of the students would one day look back at this day, their final match of sophomore year, as the moment when they finally understood what it was they were aspiring toward. The matches they'd had previously, while difficult, had been controlled by their very nature. There were always safeguards, always rules, always a set number of variables to be accounted for. In the last five minutes of their match, none of that was true. It was their first taste of true battle. There was no order, no simple objectives. There was only chaos, and fear, and violence.

And fire. All of them would remember that quite clearly. There was so very much fire.

\* \* \*

Sasha held back until the first wave of people crashed together, Roy in the center smacking away bodies like yappy dogs at his feet. She waited because she was smart, because she knew the real action was up at the area marked by the blue beam, with her ex-boyfriend impersonating a bonfire just in front of it. Sasha didn't know what was going on with him, but it didn't matter. Chad had their orb; all she needed to do was intercept any other team's depositor who looked like they might get past Vince. She needed to reposition herself, so once the initial fray began she took off from her hiding place.

Sasha was only running for a couple of seconds when she felt her legs give out from under her. She crashed heavily to the ground, the pain slapping across her body far worse than it should have been from a mere fall. She was tough, she was a speeder; she didn't get hurt from simple tumbles. With great effort she pulled herself up onto her elbows, only to fall right back down. It was insane; it was like something was pulling her down, like her body weighed hundreds of pounds. Remembering her team's match with Team One, she searched her limited field of vision for Mary, certain she was the cause of her sudden immobility. There was no sign of her, not that it would have mattered if there had been. Sasha's real problem, and the problem of many students similarly sprawled across the ground, was floating twenty feet overhead, fist clenched in concentration.

\* \* \*

Stella made it past Roy's ruckus and steered clear of the areas where

everyone seemed to have become forcibly enamored with studying the grass. The burning ground licked at her feet, but it wasn't hot enough to melt her metal body so it was easily ignorable. She didn't have her team's orb - that had been entrusted to Amber and Tiffani - however, she wasn't certain those two would be able to approach with Vince laying down random blasts of fire. They could move without being seen or heard; that didn't mean they were immune to heat stroke or sudden incineration. As if on cue, Vince lanced the ground with twin blasts of fire, one from each palm, narrowly missing Hector and Allen. Damn, Vince was not fucking around: he'd really been trying to hit them.

Her pace quickened. He might have a great offense, but once she got in close, Vince had no chance. She just needed to make it another dozen feet or so. A bit of ground gave way beneath her weight and her eyes flickered away from her target, only for a moment. It was long enough to miss the attack, not that it would have made any difference.

Stella's body went limp and her brain became useless as a barrage of electricity coursed through her. For all the protection her metallic form offered against the fire, it left her more vulnerable to attacks that could be measured in voltage. Her consciousness faded away, though not before she felt a foot step on top of her for the briefest of instants. Someone had been running behind her, using her as cover. There were a few candidates to pull off such a ballsy maneuver, but she had a hunch it was one in particular. Stella greeted the unconscious world with a smile on her lips. At least her efforts hadn't been for nothing.

\* \* \*

Mary mentally knocked a marble the size of a sedan back at Terrance, who hurriedly dodged out of the way. Checking to be sure the coast was clear, she hustled to the depository and placed her team's orb inside. She'd circled around to approach from the rear, thankful Nick had programmed Vince's delusion to see them as allies. Briefly she wondered how they appeared to him. Occasionally she would peek at his thoughts, but they were convoluted and wild; it was hard to get more than general impressions of what he was seeing. One thing she did know: however he was viewing their competitors, it was not favorably.

Vince jerked at a sudden noise and let fly a bolt of electricity directly into Stella's torso. Strange, he had only used fire until now, but he changed tactics exactly as he should have against his opponent. Mary wondered if he

was still able to discern their abilities through the haze of his hallucination. She might have investigated, but at that moment she noticed something that had escaped her attention before: Chad had been running behind Stella during her ascent, using her loud approach and attention-gathering nature to hide his own assault. When the metal girl went down, he never broke stride, stepping directly on her as he continued to approach.

For the briefest of moments Mary was tempted to intervene. Chad was incredibly powerful, no doubt about that, but at this range she still had a good chance of sending him sailing away. Mary readied herself to let fly with a telekinetic blast, then stopped. He might be able to dodge, just as he was avoiding the fireballs Vince was hurling at him. Beyond that, Nick had said all they were doing was pushing back the weaker students so Vince could face the strong ones. If ever there was a chance for Vince to prove himself, it was against Chad Taylor. Mary redirected her focus toward the rest of the students working toward their direction. She needed to keep them at bay.

If Vince was going up against Chad, he was going to need every last bit of concentration he could muster.



## 185.

Chad was more than observant, more than intuitive, and more than able to recall any memory in perfect detail. Oh, Chad was certainly all of those things, but he was something else as well: Chad was intelligent. He possessed the kernel of brilliance that allowed him to take in the details of a situation and make the leap from curiosity to explanation. In this case, however, it had been closer to a short hop.

Rich was bound and blindfolded, Nick was smiling like the Cheshire Cat, and Vince was on nothing short of a rampage. They'd brain-jacked his silver-haired opponent. Chad didn't know the how or the why; however, the evidence that it had happened spoke for itself. At the year's inception he would have ruled out such a theory, deeming it beyond Nick's capacity to execute. That had been before their team's match-up. Now Chad knew better than to discount Nick's ability to scheme. None of which changed the objective before him; it only informed on it.

The orb had to go into the depository. He'd taken it back from Julia to ensure its delivery. Vince was his obstacle. For a moment Chad had been certain Mary would join in the fracas as well, but she'd peeled off and focused elsewhere. They weren't underestimating him; this team was far too self-aware for that sort of folly. No, they sincerely believed Vince could challenge him one on one. That wasn't supported by what Chad knew of Vince's previous fights; however, that didn't make them wrong. The electricity that hit Stella had been perfect, center mass and with more than enough stopping power. Fire was raining down on Chad with such ferocity that it was all he could do to regulate his body temperature even when avoiding the main thrusts of the flames. No, this Vince wasn't fighting to win: he was fighting to end his opponents.

Chad increased his speed as he drew closer. A strange sense of happiness filled his brain just before the conflict began in earnest. Here, at last, was the potential for a decent challenge.

\* \* \*

Roy sank his fist into another Julia clone, watching it dissolve into energy. Spinning on his heel, he caught some sort of energy blast from Jill in his shoulder. There was a sizzling sound as his uniform and body hair were disintegrated at the spot where it struck. There was no pain beyond that,

thankfully, only a sort of greasy feeling. Jill changed weapons, but Roy didn't give her the chance to fire again. Bounding toward her, Roy seized the bracers on her forearms and squeezed until he heard the soft popping of breaking electronics. Before she could respond, he grabbed her helmet and pulled it in opposite directions. He split the complicated contraption like a pistachio, revealing a sweaty face and spilling blonde hair in all directions.

“Hey!”

“Don't bring toys you don't want broken,” Roy replied, hurling the pieces of helmet in different directions. He didn't know if this would really mess up her system or merely be an inconvenience, but in truth he was okay with either. There might have been more gloating if not for the massive grip that seized his leg and lifted him into the air.

Roy found himself dangling from the clutches of an exceptionally large tree. Credit where it was due: Agatha had definitely stepped up her animation ability over the course of the year. This was far more useful than some paper dolls. From the corner of his eye, Roy noticed an orange streak blur past his position. Oh hell no, there was no way he was missing out on a chance to finish things with Thomas.

“Sorry, Mr. Tree, but I'm afraid I don't have time to make this gentle.” Roy reached out, grabbed the thickest part of the branch curled around his legs, and went to work.

\* \* \*

Vince seemed to realize he couldn't hit Chad with ranged attacks; the other Super was just too quick on his feet. Rather than keep pounding away with useless tactics, Vince retreated several steps until he was directly in front of the depository. The air in front of him became thick and hazy as he blasted it with heat, creating a barrier no being of flesh could safely pass through. He lanced the ground with fire for good measure; however, this he was more careful with, lest some accidentally spread to the depository he was defending. It was a good plan, and against a great many opponents it would have been effective.

It was only through misfortune that Vince's opponent was Chad Taylor.

The wall of heat struck him suddenly, grabbing at his skin and prickling across his lungs. It would have seared him instantly; however, Chad began releasing moisture at an accelerated rate. The water evaporated as

quickly as it came, but it created a buffer that offered some protection. Small fires broke out across his uniform as bits of it spontaneously combusted at the slightest friction. Chad quickened his step and his senses. He needed to make it through soon; not even his bodily control could counter so much heat indefinitely. Bursting forward, he came within arm's reach of Vince, who had turned down the outpouring of flames in favor of creating his heat barrier.

Chad sidestepped a punch aimed at his head and stepped over a sweeping leg meant to take his footing out from under him. He could see the hole in the depository meant to receive their orbs; it was almost in reach. He used a quick-step movement forward, extending his right arm and dropping the orb into its final destination. Vince was attacking during this, of course; Chad used his left arm to deflect a few jabs aimed at his torso, then spun it around to intercept the head-shot he was certain was coming. It was a solid assumption, one built on years of training against a variety of martial styles, and against a great many opponents it would have been effective.

It was only through misfortune that Chad's opponent was Vince Reynolds.

The punch connected with Chad's ribs, and Vince poured every last bit of kinetic energy he still had stockpiled into it. For the span of a heartbeat, it seemed like there would be no effect. Then, almost at once, Chad was airborne as the unexpected force lifted him from his feet and blasted him toward the false sky.

He would be more or less okay once he landed, although that would not be for quite some time.

Shane had been approaching quietly, trying to get in range to take down Vince once more. He wasn't certain how the silver-haired student had gotten free: likely with help from his teammates. Still, he'd put Vince down once and he would do it again. That had been the plan, at least. As soon as Chad was sent rocketing off into the horizon, Shane found himself locked in a moment of indecision. There was still time to act; Vince was still vulnerable. Yes, the cloak of flames would impede Shane's shadow attacks, but parts of Vince were still unprotected. It wasn't fear or lack of strategy that stalled Shane's advance. It was friendship.

Logically, he knew Chad was okay. This was Chad, after all. No one knew him better than Shane; they'd spent the last two years working out, training, and generally hanging around with one another. Of course he would be fine. There was no tactical reason to go scurrying after him just because he'd taken a solid blow. A solid blow that had blasted him beyond the distant tree line.

"Goddamnit," Shane muttered under his breath. He shifted trajectory and tried to estimate where his only friend had landed. It was all manner of stupid, but he supposed that was part of the bargain one got with friendship. Oh well; it wasn't as if he were holding an orb anyway.

\* \* \*

"Holy crap," Mary said as she watched the blonde figure go sailing off. "I didn't expect that."

"I doubt Chad did either," Alex chuckled. His mirth was cut short as a sudden piercing wail sliced past his eardrums and began carving up his brain. He didn't have time to deflect or react, only to fall to his knees in pain. Through bleary eyes he saw Mary do the same, then noticed most of the combatants in his line of vision dropping one by one.

The exception was Amber, walking confidently forward with her lips puckered in what appeared to be a whistle. There was no cheerful springtime tone, only this hellish audible assault tearing through them. It didn't take a brilliant intellect to make the connection, but many of the students were in too much pain to spare the brain cells it would require.

One exception was Alice, floating above the crowd with an excellent

viewpoint for what was about to transpire. Amber's ability was good, but it had limits. If she'd tried to cast her painful sound all the way up to Alice then it would have been weakened in the area as a whole. Instead she allowed the supposedly useless girl go unaccosted and focused on her perceived threats. This would have been a vital mistake had it ever had the chance to become one.

The sound reached Vince and at first it seemed it would affect him just like the others. His fire nearly extinguished as his knees began to buckle. The ground loomed before him and a collapse looked inevitable. He glanced at his attacker, undisguised hatred etched in his face, and made a motion with his hand.

The sound, all sound, in fact, was immediately gone. Instants later the crackling of wild fires and general din of battle reasserted itself; however, for one brief instant their world was completely and utterly quiet. It was for that reason that no one heard the stretching of muscle or creaking of bone as Vince pulled himself back to a standing position, eyes locked on the woman who'd tried to bring him down.

Amber was stunned, both figuratively, then moments later literally as she was struck by a high voltage of electricity. A fireball on its heels smashed into her shoulder, burning her left side and sending her rolling back several feet onto the ground.

\* \* \*

Thomas slowed his approach. His energy armor had protected him from Amber's noise, after he'd taken some damage before he reoriented it to keep out sound. The energy was malleable by its nature; however, in the middle of a fight there was usually no advantage in stopping sound. In fact, such an action would be detrimental. It was because of this protection that he didn't notice the shock of quiet, nor did he understand the implications of it. Instead all he saw was Vince momentarily succumb to the pain then rally his strength and fire back at Amber, ending her attack and taking her out of the fight. This was strange, but Thomas had known Vince for years. The silver-haired boy had shown impressive depths of strength and resolve before. These actions still fit within what Thomas considered possible.

This mistake, unlike Amber's, would very much come back to haunt him.

\* \* \*

“Did you know Vince could absorb sound?” Camille asked as they hauled themselves up from the grass.

“Not specifically, but I never saw any reason why he wouldn’t be capable of it,” Nick replied. He picked up Rich with as much care as he could; their captive was having trouble reorienting himself after Amber’s attack. “There’s not much principle difference between sound and some of the other energies he uses. Once we found out kinetic was on the table I assumed there were other things Vince either didn’t know about or wasn’t using.”

“Would have been great in his fight with Selena.”

“Agreed.” Nick looked at the recovered form of his friend. The flames had increased back to their blinding point, making him hard to look at directly. “Still, I was expecting more.”

“More than this?”

“Yes, actually. This exceeds what most people would have considered possible from Vince, but not me.”

“Why would you expect something beyond what you considered possible?” Camille asked pointedly. Nick almost forgot that the small girl had honed instincts where Vince was concerned. That was good: the big dope needed looking after, and once this was done she’d have more of it to do.

“Never mind that for now,” Nick replied. “Follow me. There’s one last thing we need to do before this is all over.”

Camille didn’t like it, but she followed anyway. She’d come too far to turn back now.

## 187.

While the bright orange glow enveloping Thomas would normally have made stealth a distant impossibility, the downside to Vince's outpouring of flames was that orange light didn't exactly stand out in his field of vision. In fact, given the circumstances, Thomas's energy armor was quite possibly the best camouflage he could have asked for. That was why he was able to close the gap and draw near his opponents without having to waste too much energy diverting fire or electricity. The area around him still required dealing with; however, Vince offered no direct assaults before Thomas got in range for his own attack.

He wasted no time, slamming Vince with a fist of orange energy, then immediately enveloping the silver-haired student in a cocoon of the stuff. Unlike during their fight freshman year, Thomas did not grab only his opponent's torso. This time he wrapped Vince from head to toe, with a few open spots beneath the feet to allow air flow. Thomas had been taken by surprise when Vince fired from his eyes once before; it was a not a mistake he was eager to repeat.

It wasn't until Vince was entirely imprisoned and suspended ten feet above the ground that Thomas allowed himself any sense of relief. This hadn't been how he wanted a rematch with Vince, but his friend was causing too much damage and firing too indiscriminately. If no one stopped him there was a good chance he would really hurt somebody. Deep within Thomas's core, he might have been willing to admit that part of the reason he'd undertaken this fight was as a test to see if he had what it took to bring down the man who had so far deflected all challengers. Call it hubris, pride, or simple curiosity: Thomas had wanted to test himself, and he was rather pleased with the results.

A crackling sound filled the air, originating from the cylindrical sphere that was currently encasing Vince. The next thing Thomas knew, a strange sensation was filling his body. He would struggle for months to accurately describe it, never quite managing to put into words how it felt. Many would suggest it was a sense of being drained, but that didn't fit with what he'd experienced. Thomas would ultimately land on the word 'peeled' to encapsulate the sensation. It was like someone were peeling apart the layers of his very existence. It didn't occur to him until after the fact to wonder where those layers were going.

Vince fell to the ground, landing carefully on his feet. He'd ceased the barrage of flames, yet he still glowed with an orange light, a strange effect from the arc of energy flowing to him from his former captor. Thomas's armor dissolved, swept into the transfer before he had a chance to even think of some attempt at salvaging it. Then it was over; the arc had vanished and Thomas found himself staring across an all-too small distance at his friend, who was still glowing softly from the cascade of stolen power. He stared into those eyes, seeing the absolute malice naked within them. Thomas was never proud of his next action; however, he refused to be ashamed of it either. Given all that had happened to him in less than a minute, it was a perfectly sound tactical decision.

Thomas spun on his heel and ran like hell.

\* \* \*

"Now that, I was not expecting," Nick admitted, his breathing still surprisingly even for the speed at which he was moving while hauling along a prisoner.

"He really did what it looked like, right? He just absorbed Thomas's energy," Camille said, unable to keep the shock from her voice. She'd thought knocking away Chad had been the game-changer they were hoping for, but this was on a whole other level. Energy absorbers were rare, but Vince was hardly one of a kind. Her own type of absorption was far less common than his, in fact. That said, his kind were almost always limited to certain types of energy, and natural kinds at that. For him to be able to absorb such a broad spectrum was one thing. For Vince to be able to absorb the crafted energy of another Super, that probably put Vince in the top tier of known Supers.

"He did it all right," Nick said. "Now let's just make sure everyone gets the implications." He came to a stop before a female form lying on the ground. It fluttered its eyes open at his approach; clearly the seeming slumber had only been a facade meant to make her appear helpless.

"How are you feeling, Amber?"

A painful groan was all that met their ears - clearly either the shock or the fire had impacted her ability to speak - though Nick noticed she was moving the fingers on her left hand into a position to snap if needed.

"No need for that; we come in peace. In fact, I'm going to offer to make you feel a lot better. You see, this is going to be over pretty soon, and when it ends there are a lot of people who need healing. You're in pain, but



you're far from critical, so who knows how long it will be until your turn comes up? If you do me a small favor, however, I'll have Camille heal you right here and now. Poof, no more burned skin."

Amber stared at him with hard eyes; however, she moved her fingers in twirling motion, indicating for him to continue.

"All I want is for you to amplify my voice. I have an announcement to make, and it's going to take a lot to be heard over this ruckus."

She continued staring at him, giving no indication of acceptance or rejection. Nick could see the wheels spinning in her head, trying to figure out if this was some trick.

"We've only got around thirty seconds left, and if you think me yelling is going to do anything that Vince's rampage hasn't then you give me far more credit than even my impressive ego thinks I deserve," he told her.

Finally Amber nodded her agreement. The nerves on her shoulder were too damaged to feel the light touch of Camille's finger, but she immediately noticed the sense of relief as her pain began to wither into nothingness. Nick allowed her to be almost entirely patched up before motioning he was ready to begin.

He took a deep breath and surveyed the landscape one last time. His friends, still battling fiercely as time ran low, the scent of burning foliage that had become thick through the arena, the familiar sounds of combat, even as the point of it all became increasingly obscured. This was a madhouse, a place of carnage and insanity and utter disconnection from the real world. He'd loved it here.

"HEY, YOU FUCKING SUITS WATCHING THE SHOW!" Nick yelled, his already-hollered words blasting through the arena with incredible clarity. Amber definitely lived up to her side of the bargain, no question about that. He adjusted his tone slightly to allow for variation. "This is Nicholas Campbell. The silver-haired demon I've mind-controlled into beating the shit out of everyone who gets near him is Vince Reynolds. Former Powered. Adopted son of the villain Globe. Ass-kicking machine. My best friend."

The last words Nick said more to himself than his audience, although Amber's power carried them just the same. A brief chime sounded as the beam centered on the depository turned back to red. The window was closed. The match was over.

“You all just watched him knock back several top ranks, including Chad Taylor, our current king of the combat mountain. So I just wanted to ask you a quick question, while I had the opportunity.” Nick filled his lungs and raised his voice for one last bit of his speech. “WHO’S MIDDLE OF THE PACK NOW, MOTHER FUCKERS?!”

"If I didn't know better I would swear your real ability is creating giant shitstorms," Dean Blaine said as he walked in the door. He was worn and weary; the last few hours had taken a toll equivalent to several days' worth of work. Professor Pendleton was hot on his heels, shutting the door behind them as they entered. To his credit, Nick sat calmly at the table where he'd been restrained since the climax of the match.

It had been about three hours since the incident that had left a large chunk of the arena smoldering and many of the sophomores bound for the infirmary. Dean Blaine had done his best to handle the fires, both literal and metaphorical; however, the surprisingly nonplussed young man sitting in front of him was still the biggest issue to deal with.

"I don't think I need to tell you why you're here," Dean Blaine continued, taking a seat across from Nick. Professor Pendleton chose to remain standing. "However, for the sake of procedure, I'm obligated to do so anyway." He produced a small device from his pocket and clicked a button near the top. A red LED light flickered on immediately. Nick had seen enough recording devices to recognize them with ease. This one hadn't been concealed at all, and he had no doubt there were a few scattered around this concrete room purposely placed out of sight.

"Nicholas Campbell, you have been accused of threatening the life of Rich Weaver, using improper force on a clone of Julia Shaw without confirming whether it was the real student, and overtaking Vince Reynolds' brain then making him use dangerous levels of force on his fellow classmates," Dean Blaine recited. "Do you understand the charges that have been leveled at you?"

Nick spoke at last, the first words he'd uttered since his amplified monologue on the battle field. "Not only do I understand them, I confess to all of them."

Dean Blaine resisted the urge to show any outward signs of surprise. "Are you sure you want to do that?"

"Positive," Nick replied. "I told Rich I'd cut his throat with the broken plastic shard from my sunglasses. You can check my coat pocket if you don't believe that I've got it. I whacked Julia in the cranium with enough power to

do serious brain damage if it hadn't been a clone. I might have even killed her. As for Vince... well, I think my confession there has already been witnessed by plenty of people. Still, for the sake of record, I admit to forcing Rich to place Vince in a delusion where he believed he was fighting inhuman beasts to protect someone innocent. Vince is no more accountable than any other victim of mind or body control; any crimes he committed are considered to be mine under the precedent set forth in *The State versus Magical Mind Master*. If you need to check the case for it, I believe it occurred in nineteen sixty seven."

"Of course you already memorized the legal precedents," Dean Blaine muttered to himself. "Okay, Nick, you've confessed. I don't suppose you'd care to tell us why you did all this?"

"The first two crimes were merely to facilitate the third. Vince needed the chance to show what he could do. I wanted to give him that chance. This was the best method I could come up with."

"Bullshit," Professor Pendleton snapped. "I've taught you for a year, I know how brilliant you really are. There were other ways to do this, and you could have found them."

"Maybe there were better ways," Nick conceded. "Then again, maybe those ways came with different costs. Ones that I didn't think were worth paying. Or maybe I'm not quite as smart as everyone seems to think, and I couldn't find them. I guess we'll never know."

"Actually we will," Dean Blaine corrected him. "This investigation will certainly merit the use of a telepath."

"I think my lawyer will disagree," Nick replied. "Telepaths can only be officially used against the subject's will when they are under investigation. You can't claim to be investigating me, I already confessed. In fact, official use of a telepath on any of the parties involved in this, now that all the charges have been confessed to, would be a violation of their fourth amendment rights and grounds for a very aggressive lawsuit."

Dean Blaine felt his hand clench into a fist involuntarily. "Let me guess: you'll be sharing your legal resources with all involved should that occur."

"It is the least I can do to make amends for my awful actions in the arena today," Nick said, sincerity all but dripping from his voice. The educators were not impressed.

“I suppose that’s all there is to say then,” Dean Blaine noted. He reached over and turned off the small device with a casual gesture. Once the light was off, he turned back to Nick with a firm look in his eyes. “All right, Nick, now it’s just the three of us. You want to tell me what the hell you were really thinking out there?”

“The truth is very close to the lie,” Nick said. “I wanted to help my friend. This was the path that minimized risk and maximized potential for success.”

“So you torched your potential future to try and save Vince’s,” Professor Pendleton summarized.

“Gentlemen, the time for deception is over; let’s not pretend I had a clear path to graduation. I might be smart, fast, and adaptable, but my power is never going to place me in the same class as people like Chad, Vince, or Alice. I probably would have made it through this year, and even that would only be due to Professor Pendleton’s glowing recommendation. Passing third year would have been a long shot, and making it into the final ten was almost a certain impossibility. I was never going to walk down the stage and hear them call me a Hero. Vince, on the other hand, has a real chance at that dream. More importantly, he’s the kind of person who should be wearing that title.”

Nick paused for a moment, a rare unintended theatricality. Honesty was hard for him; it took actual effort to coax the words forth.

“It’s no secret to you two where I come from or how I was raised. I spent most of my life believing everyone had an angle, that even the best people in the world were still capable of selfishness and deception. Vince is the first person I’ve ever met who doesn’t fall into that category. He isn’t perfect, but most of his mistakes are due to lack of understanding or fear of hurting someone else. I’ve seen him put other people first without a second thought more times than I can count. The way I see it, if someone is such a decent human being that he can make a guy like me have a little faith, then that’s the kind of person who people should be looking up to and calling Hero.”

“I get it,” Dean Blaine said, much of the fire gone from his voice. “Sean and I came up through this program, too. I understand how you can arrive at the decision to put someone else’s well-being above your own. The problem facing us right now is how to deal with the fallout from your actions.”

“You have to expel me,” Nick said plainly. “I have to be forcibly ousted from the Hero Certification Program.”

Dean Blaine and Professor Pendleton exchange a brief glance. “That would be standard protocol; however, there is something you need to understand about what happens when we do expel a student.”

“I figured it out already. I’ve known since freshman year.” Nick sighed and reached up to adjust the sunglasses that were no longer on his face. Well, at least he didn’t have to worry about breaking that habit.

“You’re going to erase my memory.”

Vince heard the door to the infirmary open softly then close quickly. He didn't bother opening his eyes or getting up from the bed where he was laying. It was time for another round of questioning. They'd been coming at irregular intervals to ask what had happened, what he had seen, why he'd done the things he'd done. No one really seemed to like his answers. It wasn't his fault that the details were fuzzy; it had been a hectic battle. Add in the natural strangeness of coming back from a Rich hallucination and it was a miracle he could remember anything besides the hellish fighting. He hadn't even believed their accounts of his actions at first; they seemed well beyond the limits of what he could do. The videos they showed him silenced those objections immediately.

"Hey, Silver, how you feeling?"

Vince's eyes shot open and he jerked upright. He'd been expecting a professor or the dean again, maybe even one of his teammates. The absolute last person he'd expected to step through the door was Nick, who was currently walking toward him at a careful pace. That was understandable; Nick probably didn't know how Vince would react to what he'd done. For that matter, Vince wasn't all that sure either.

"Healed, but shaken up," Vince replied honestly. "They let you come see me?"

"I convinced them I wanted to come apologize," Nick lied. "Sort of a last request, since there's no time to cook me a meal."

"They're kicking you out." For once Vince was quick on the uptake. Nick was thankful for that; he hadn't been looking forward to walking him to the appropriate conclusion.

"Yeah. There are people at Melbrook packing my bags as we speak. I'll be on the road before sunset."

"That's so quick. Isn't there some sort of trial or investigation they have to go through?"

"There would be, if I hadn't confessed," Nick replied. "I admitted guilt on all charges and offered no excuse for mitigation. My expulsion was pretty much a lock anyway; I just saved people the time and energy they'd

spend justifying it.”

“Oh.” Vince looked down at his sheets, idly wondering how many times he’d been in this infirmary during his second year at Lander. He seemed to have lost count. “So, are you going to do it?”

“Do what?”

“Apologize.” Vince looked up, meeting his friend’s eyes without the tinted plastic divider. “You took over my brain. You made me hurt our classmates. Some of them were even our friends. And the things I saw... it was not a pretty vision.”

“I didn’t imagine it would be,” Nick admitted. “I made Rich give you a structure that would get rid of that pesky need to hold back you’re always plagued with. I had a feeling it was going to be something nasty. I’m sorry for the guilt you feel, Vince. That I can say with honesty. As for the rest, I wouldn’t recommend holding your breath.”

“You don’t feel bad about it?”

“I don’t feel bad about most things. Until I got here I could say I felt bad about almost nothing. For all the things I have begun to experience guilt over, this will never be one of them. Yes, I gave you the fuel for some nightmares, but you already have plenty of that. Yeah, I added some guilt to the burden you walk around with, but it’s a fraction of what was already there. That stuff sucks, but you know what doesn’t? Right now everyone is talking about how to deal with me, and whether the battle system needs reform to stop the kind of hijinks I used from being repeated. You know what not one person is talking about? Vince Reynolds being cut from the program. Because after what you did in that arena, no one is so fucking stupid to think that suggestion could get any traction.”

“What I did in the arena,” Vince repeated. “What I did in there was brutal. It was horrible. I didn’t even think about if the enemies I was attacking could withstand the attacks I was giving them.”

“Yet everyone survived just fine,” Nick pointed out. “I’ve been telling you, these people are stronger than you give them credit for. That said, when you finally went at it full force, you were unstoppable.”

“I was a monster,” Vince said, his voice somewhere between a whisper and a pained sigh.



“Vince, do you know what the difference between monsters and angels is? It’s whether they’re on your side or not.”

“That doesn’t make sense.”

“Sure it does. Let’s take you, for example. You say that you were a monster out there. I won’t deny that. The power you displayed, the things you accomplished, they were inhuman. So yes, when you stop holding back, you could most certainly be considered a monster. Now, let’s look down the line. One day, ten years from now when you’re a professional Hero, you get a call about a Super trying to rob a bank and taking hostages. You show up, pissed off, and you show him the same beast that everyone saw today. To that criminal, to that poor stupid bastard, you would certainly be a monster that haunts him for the rest of his life.”

“If you meant this to be comforting then you really missed the mark,” Vince interrupted.

“Let me finish,” Nick said. “The point is that to him, you are a monster. To the hostages in that bank, on the other hand, you would be an angel. The same things that make you so scary to the bad guys will make you comforting to the innocent people. When someone says you’re on the way, everyone in the right will know things are going to be okay, and everyone in the wrong will be getting on good terms with any god that will have them. Don’t be afraid of how dangerous your power makes you. That fear belongs to the people who have to reckon with you.”

“You have a knack for speeches,” Vince said, shifting his gaze slightly.

“One of my many talents. So, do you forgive me?”

“I thought you weren’t apologizing.”

“I’m not. But since when have you needed an act of contrition to forgive someone?”

Vince smiled at his friend. “I forgive you. And thank you for helping me. Not to mention showing me what I could do. For the life of me I can’t figure out how you knew I had all that in me. I didn’t even realize I could absorb sound or created energy.”

“Honestly, I didn’t know any of that either,” Nick admitted. “I just had faith in you.”

“That is some impressive faith.”

“I learned from the best.” Nick patted his best friend on the shoulder. He was going to miss this crazy bastard. Vince definitely made things less predictable. “You know that from now on things are going to get harder, right? I’ve worked in the background to try and keep you guys sheltered from a lot of crap, but I won’t be able to do that anymore.”

“Well, I’ll say this much,” Vince said. “After watching that video and seeing the way people are acting around me, I’m feeling strong enough to handle any challenges that come our way.”

Nick dearly hoped his friend was right.

## 190.

“How’d it go?” Professor Pendleton asked as Nick emerged from the infirmary. The visit had been quicker than he anticipated, yet Nick seemed considerably more upbeat leaving than he had going in. Certainly he was happier than he should have been, or than Professor Pendleton was feeling. In the year he’d been teaching he’d come to care about many of his pupils; however, Nick was something special. It galled him to see his prized student being flung out the door, but there was nothing to do for it. Nick had chosen his path and he’d structured it so well that it was all but impossible to stop him.

“We’re good,” Nick replied. “Although I’m not sure what his sentiment will be toward me once he finds out the full extent of my punishment.” The two began walking down the hallway. Professor Pendleton was officially his escort, unofficially his prison guard. Not that anyone really thought Nick would make a run for it after going to such great lengths to put himself in custody, but they’d all been around him long enough to know that the minute you thought you knew what Nick was planning was the moment he had you right where he wanted you.

“You didn’t tell him about the policy?”

Nick shook his head. “He’ll find out soon enough. No reason to break it to him without his friends around.”

“It’s not too late,” Professor Pendleton told him. “You could still lobby for just failing the year rather than a full expulsion. The wipe is far less extensive for that.”

“Good to know, but I’m okay with this. It’s the best way for me to leave.”

“With no memory of your experiences or your friends?”

“Look, I just willingly gave up a sweet cover I’d maintained for two years and got myself booted from this program in order to help someone, all with no payoff for me,” Nick grumbled. The duo took a turn and began walking down a different hallway. “These people, this place, all of it has infected me with... sentiment. It’s been fun, but I have to go back to my real world now. And going back as a softer, kinder Nick is likely to get me in serious trouble. If I’m going home, it’s better I go back as the cunning and

efficient version of myself.”

“You really want to burn away all the progress you’ve made in your time here?”

“That’s why I built a pyre. What you witnessed in that arena was the funeral of Lander’s Nick Campbell.” They took another turn; it was only a few minutes to the room where Nick would make his final exit from Lander. “For what it’s worth, thank you.”

“Because I tried to talk you out of it?” Professor Pendleton asked.

“Because you really went out of your way to be a good teacher to me,” Nick explained. “Even though my cover made it hard, you still made sure I got a solid education. I wish I could say I won’t forget that, but we both know it wouldn’t be true.”

“You’re welcome,” Professor Pendleton said. “As a student you are a colossal pain in the ass, but you also have more skill and potential than I’ve ever seen in someone your age. I was looking forward to teaching you next year.”

“Maybe one day in the future,” Nick said. “Speaking of future, I have a goodbye present being delivered to you later today. Consider it my version of an apple on the desk.”

“That’s an unexpectedly kind gesture,” Professor Pendleton said.

“Wait until you see it before you say that,” Nick rebutted.

“Well, it at least evens the score for us. I got you something, too.”

They turned the final corner; however, instead of just an open hallway leading to a thick door, there stood a blonde girl five feet down it, tapping her foot on the ground and looking fifteen shades of pissed off.

“You dick,” Nick muttered. He raised his voice to deliver his greeting. “Hey, Alice. How’s it hanging?”

“I’ll leave you two to talk,” Professor Pendleton said. “I think I’ll stand a few feet down the last hallway. You’ve got a couple of minutes.” With that, he turned around and headed back in the direction they’d come from. His coat had barely vanished behind the corner before Alice spoke.

“You’re leaving.”

“It seems you caught me,” Nick admitted.

“You’re leaving without saying goodbye.” She began walking toward him, posture somewhere between preparing to deck him and grabbing him in a hug.

“School policy. They tend to be brutally efficient when kicking someone out the door.”

“They also tend to fog over their memories so they can’t divulge any other students’ identities,” Alice added, her approach slowing as she drew within arm’s reach of him. “Didn’t think I’d know that, right?”

“Your father filled you in, I assume,” Nick sighed. “Did you tell the others?”

“No, but I would have if Mr. Transport had told me what was going on. Evidently Professor Pendleton sent a message to get me down here with no explanation. I put the pieces together while I was waiting.”

“Alice Adair, always too smart for her own good.”

“So you were just going to leave us? No hugs, no notes, no nothing?”

“Like I said, policy,” Nick defended. “At least they were nice enough to let me talk to Vince. As for the rest of you, well, I left something as a sort of farewell. You’ll see later tonight.”

“You knew you were doing this. You could have said something before it all went down.”

“Actually, I couldn’t have. Keeping you all in the dark was the best method I had for protecting you. None of you knew what I had planned, so they can’t try and spread the blame around. It was all me. I did the crime, now I’m doing the time.”

“I... ah fuck, I guess I already knew that deep down,” Alice said, her voice dropping several octaves. She reached out and took his hand, gently resting it in hers. “I realize you did all of this for Vince, and for us. What about you, though? What about the things you said on the beach? How even a man like you once wanted to be the hero. To make the world a better place.”

“Alice, this was that moment. Someone like me could never really cross over, never let go of how he was raised and the things he’s done. Even if I had made it to Hero, I wouldn’t have done the role justice, not the way

Vince could. So I put all my chips on Silver. If he makes it, then I get to know that every life he saves is in part because of me.”

“That sounds far more noble than the Nick I know,” Alice chuckled, moving in closer.

“Like I said, too smart for her own good,” Nick agreed. They were very close now; he could smell the shampoo coating her long hair and spot the red areas around her eyes that told him she’d been crying. “Alice, you know I won’t remember any of this.”

“I know.”

“But you will.”

“So be it.”

With that she closed the gap, and for the first time in over a year, they were kissing. It was slower than last time, less frantic than in Alice’s intoxicated attack. This wasn’t a kindling or a beginning. This was a kiss goodbye.

It is impossible to say how long they were like that, only that they were interrupted by the coughing of Professor Pendleton. The two pulled away from each other, then exchanged a glance more awkward and genuine than either would have believed themselves still capable of. Professor Pendleton started forward, heading toward the room.

Time was up.

Alice started to move away, but Nick pulled her in once more, placing his lips carefully against her ears and speaking in the softest of whispers.

“Never forget who I am.”

Then he was gone, closing the gap to Professor Pendleton and walking through the door that would seal his fate.

Mr. Numbers stepped carefully around the workers diligently packing away Nick Campbell's belongings. They'd just arrived, but from the speed with which they were moving, it wouldn't be long until they were finished. It made sense; the HCP booted a lot of students in their freshman year. Having a competent moving staff would be an absolute necessity. Mr. Transport had agreed to teleport the cargo to Vegas once it was ready; at least they could save Nick the trouble of hauling it in his small car.

Weaving through the rapid workers, Mr. Numbers made his way to a modest shelf positioned above Nick's computer. Stacked neatly, in alphabetical order, were at least two dozen DVDs, all of them terrible slasher films perfectly suited to Nick's tastes. Reading through the titles, Mr. Numbers located the film he needed, *Brazilian Bloodsuckers 6: The AB Negative Wars*, and pulled it from the shelf. It made a brief journey into his coat pocket, and he turned to exit the room. No one made any move to stop him, nor had he expected them to.

Mentally, Mr. Numbers checked the item from his to-do list. This was his only acquisition; the next three tasks were deliveries. Normally he was not the type to run errands for others, but in light of Nick's actions, he had allowed himself to be talked into it. Still, when Nick had given him the sealed envelope of instructions and the two packages, he'd never expected the sarcastic student to actually go through with any of the plans that got him thrown out. He was certain there would be some last minute twist, which only went to show that despite his age and ability, even Mr. Numbers could occasionally be surprised.

\* \* \*

"Nick Campbell," Dean Blaine said, his voice purposely raised and clear. There were only four people in the room, so it was a bit more effort than was necessary, but he made a point to keep everything in these proceedings as open and filled with clarity as possible. "For the violations to which you have confessed, you are being expelled from the Hero Certification Program. This means that you cannot reapply for junior year, or any year, at any location. You are forever barred from this program. Do you understand?"

"Crystal clear," Nick said. Professor Pendleton sat next to him, trying to keep his face neutral. It was more effort than he would have expected.

“Good. Now, whenever a student leaves our program, it is necessary to take certain precautions to ensure they cannot divulge information about the facilities or their fellow students. Professor Stone is here to facilitate those precautions.”

“Yeah, yeah, you’re going to wipe my memories so that I won’t know the secret identities of any of the Supers I trained with in case some make it to Hero.”

“Not the whole thing,” Dean Blaine corrected. “Admittedly, it will be more extensive than if you’d simply failed. Then we would only obscure memories of individuals, blurring out their names and faces, if you will. You would still retain all memory of your training, classes, and exercises. As is, you will still retain some memories from the last two years. Legally we cannot obscure any of your regular curriculum Lander classes. This meeting will also be preserved, so that you understand why there is a giant gap in your recollection. Everything else will be stripped away. Right now the packing team is also editing any photographs or documentation in your room. There will be no record of anything you experienced here in the HCP, mental or otherwise.”

“So, just to be clear, is this a psychic thing or a brain damage thing?” Nick asked. “I know it won’t change the outcome, but if you’re blowing up brain cells, I think I’d like to schedule an MRI for when I get home.”

“Your brain will be fine,” Professor Stone informed him, her voice softer than Dean Blaine’s, though not by much. “My particular telepathy allows me to interact with people’s memories. I can view them or obscure them; however, that last part is generally kept confidential.”

“I assumed it was someone on staff,” Nick replied. “You can’t very well have every bitter young adult you kick out of this thing go off with full knowledge of everyone’s names and abilities. Secret identities wouldn’t last five minutes after a new Hero’s debut.”

“I’m glad you understand the reason why we do this,” Dean Blaine said. “Now, as for your academic record, you’ve maintained good grades at Lander’s regular classes, and those will transfer to any university you’d care to attend, should you decide to continue your education. Your time in the HCP will count for various elective credits: gym, humanities, that sort of thing. You’ll have a transcript that will keep you on track for a four-year college career.”



“That’s awfully kind of you.”

“It’s policy. Just because someone didn’t make it in the HCP doesn’t mean they deserve to have their regular education set back. Besides, elective requirements are largely bullshit anyway.”

“Amen,” Nick agreed.

“So, you understand what will happen, and what your options forward from here are. When we finish you’ll be free to go. Your things have already been packed and delivered, and we will help you find your car in case the memory of that is stricken as well. Do you have any questions or statements before we begin?”

“Sort of feels like you’re asking me if I have any last words.”

“In a way, I suppose I am,” Dean Blaine admitted. He disliked this portion of the job more than almost any other. It was part of the agreement each student signed, to sacrifice bits of their memory in the event they didn’t make it, but still it always nagged at Dean Blaine. He felt like he was stripping away a piece of each person, tearing out chunks of what comprised them. It was a necessary sacrifice, he knew that, because it was better to lose a tenth of a person than to watch a whole one be killed through leaked information. That didn’t make him hate it any less.

Nick smiled. “You guys put on a good program. I had a lot of fun in my time here. I learned more than I ever expected to. I made friends, which surprised even me. I guess if I had to give one statement to summarize the whole experience, it’s that I have no regrets about coming here.” He turned in his chair to face Professor Pendleton. “That, and I hope that when you get your gift, you’ll be able to forgive what I’m about to do.”

“What do you mean?” Professor Pendleton asked.

Nick gave no verbal response; instead, he rose from his chair and crossed the room, walking around the large wooden table, coming to a stop in front of Professor Stone. He sat down next to her and closed his eyes.

“Let’s get this show on the road.”

There was a light knock on the door of Rich Weaver's dorm. He pulled himself from his bed without much enthusiasm. After the day he'd had all he wanted to do was go to fucking sleep. The only silver lining was that his roommate had already left town, since he was not obligated to stick around for questioning on today's fiasco. The official stance on who passed and who failed was that if you weren't spoken to then you should assume you had a place to come back to next year. New rankings would be announced at the start of next year, pending the results of the investigation into the Vince incident. With all that out of the way, the only thing Rich had left on his mind was rest, but now some knocking asshole had taken even that from him.

Rich jerked open the door to find a relatively short man in a dark suit staring at him.

"What do you want? I don't have to be out until tomorrow at noon."

"I brought you a package from Nick Campbell," the man said. He pulled a small envelope out from his jacket pocket and handed it to Rich. It was thin, with only a single bulge at the lower left corner. As Rich's fingers closed around it he realized it was about the right size for a flash drive. Probably one containing a video file.

"Is this the only one?" He'd have preferred to play it cool; however, this was too important to have signals get crossed.

"To my knowledge," the man said simply.

Rich grunted his acknowledgement and closed the door. He'd have liked a little more reassurance, but it looked like this is all he was getting. At least Nick had lived up to his part of the bargain. He'd turned over the evidence and managed to keep the telepaths off of Rich's back. The day had been terrible, and with the small envelope in his hand, he could finally put the whole thing in the past.

Rich reared back and smashed the envelope down on his dresser, making sure his palm drove the device into the hardest corner. He repeated this motion a dozen times until all that would eventually come tumbling out were bits of plastic and hunks of metal.

Professor Pendleton sat at his desk, a glass of whiskey in front of him and a romance novel to his side. Not even the dashing adventure of Rodrigo could take his mind off the day's events, though the whiskey was having a good bit more success. He swallowed another wretched mouthful. It was swill he'd picked up at the corner gas station. Good booze was for celebrating; it was meant to be joyfully toasted with. There was nothing he found worth celebrating today. This was whiskey for mourning.

"Afternoon," said a voice from his doorway. Professor Pendleton looked up to see Mr. Numbers standing there, strangely unbothered to walk in on an educator drinking at his desk.

"Afternoon," Professor Pendleton echoed. "Can I get you a glass?"

"Thank you, but no; I've still got some errands to run," Mr. Numbers replied. He was thankful he'd been given this task instead of Mr. Transport; that man would have sat here drinking and commiserating through half the night.

"Ah, I take it to mean you come bringing my goodbye present. I don't suppose Nick told you what it was?"

"I'm afraid not," Mr. Numbers replied. He produced a wide envelope, one made for greeting cards, with a thick wax seal on the back. "In fact, he was very adamant I not open it. Said it would defeat the entire purpose."

"Cryptic and effective. The kid was good." Professor Pendleton took another gulp as he realized he'd referred to Nick in the past tense. It wasn't incorrect, he just hated himself for adapting to the change so easily.

Mr. Numbers set the envelope on the desk. Professor Pendleton made no motion to pick it up. He would eventually - no man could resist such temptation of curiosity - but for the moment he was content to dwell in this moment of misery.

"Have a good night," Mr. Numbers said, knowing the sentiment was wasted, yet trying to express it anyway. Perhaps Mr. Transport was rubbing off on him after all these years.

Professor Pendleton nodded his understanding and refilled his glass.

\* \* \*

It took some hours for quiet to settle in at Melbrook Hall. News and comprehension of Nick's departure was greeted by railing, frustration, and

even some tears. Eventually, as evening overtook the afternoon, the four remaining Melbrook students, along with Camille, sat in the common room in silence, punctuated by an occasional thought or recollection. It was only then that Mr. Numbers and Mr. Transport appeared, emerging quietly from their apartment in the rear of the building.

“I see everyone has come to terms with the loss of one of our own,” Mr. Numbers observed.

“What Mr. Numbers means to say is that we know this is a trying time for all of you, so we wanted to come out and make sure everyone was holding up all right,” Mr. Transport corrected.

There was a chorus of mumbled groans; however, nothing remained to be said. It had all been vocalized earlier on. Now the weary din of acceptance had settled in.

“Since no one seems to have any pressing issues, we can move on,” Mr. Numbers surmised. “Before his departure, Nick made certain preparations in case this series of events played out. One of those was requesting me to relay a message to you all.”

He couldn’t have gotten their attention faster if he’d announced a giant dinosaur was attacking the campus.

“What was it?” Vince asked, his voice half hopeful and half terrified.

“Nick knew you’d all be saddened by losing him; however, he hated the idea of you all moping about. He said he’d rather be remembered with joy and annoyance, the same things he worked so hard to bring into your boring lives.” Mr. Numbers paused as he surveyed the looks he was getting. “Those are his words, not mine. Anyway, to that effect, he had me take one of his DVDs before it was packed. It was his sincere last wish that you all watch it together instead of sitting about moping. Again, his words.” Mr. Numbers pulled the DVD from his jacket pocket and set it on the coffee table.

“It’s a dumb slasher movie,” Alice noted. “That son of a bitch. He got us one last time.” And then Alice did something she would have thought impossible only moments before. She laughed. Not a sweet giggle or a half-hearted chuckle: a full-bodied gale of laughter that shook the chair she sat on. Before long the others had joined in, and it was quite a while before the mirth finally subsided enough for someone to put the disk in. Alice undertook this task, setting up the TV and DVD player before returning to her seat.

The title screen rose before them, a trio of dark skinned women with cheap plastic fangs set in their mouths. Hershel grabbed the remote and hit the Play button. What appeared on the screen was not a government warning about piracy or a preview for another movie. It was, in fact, the last thing any of them expected to see.

“Hey there,” Nick called from the screen. “Damn I wish I could see your faces right now. I bet you all look so shocked it’s ridiculous.”

He would not have been disappointed.

Nick was sitting in the computer chair in his room, back to the window which showed just a hint of the dark sky outside. His sunglasses were still on his face, which made sense since this must have been done before everything happened. He wore his usual easygoing grin as he paused for effect, letting everyone adjust to the sight of him suddenly on the television screen. After a few seconds, he continued.

“So, I’m sure you’re wondering what the hell this is about. If you’re watching this, then I had to go with my less enjoyable plan at our final match, which means assuming Mr. Numbers didn’t fuck up the timing, by now my memory of this place and all of you has been erased.”

There was no mumble of surprise; Alice had shared her findings with the group and they’d already been forced to make peace with it.

“I know that fact probably saddens all of you; hell, it sort of saddens me too, but I need you guys to know that it was absolutely necessary. With the reemergence of Globe and Vince’s connection to him, we were all going to be under increased scrutiny. My devious shenanigans would have put me on their radar as well. That means they’ll try to bring in telepaths, likely unofficially if they think they can get away with it. Now I’m sure I gave you all noble reasons for everything I did, and those are likely all at least partly true. Actions can be motivated by many things, and in this case there is one I know I didn’t tell any of you about. The things I’ve put together can, under no circumstances, be allowed to get picked up by some thought-pillaging mind delver. No offense, Mary.”

“A little bit taken,” Mary mumbled.

“For most of you this doesn’t make sense, but you need to think of things in a larger perspective. Once I realized it was almost unavoidable that they’d bring in telepaths under the radar, it became a question of not if I would give away too many secrets, but when. I can control what I say all day long; marshaling my thoughts is a different story. So, when faced with a situation that holds an inevitable outcome, what do you do? Simple, you change the situation. In my case, I got rid of the very thing that would have caused us the most grief: me. Or rather, all the knowledge I’d accumulated.”

Nick paused on the tape, reaching over to his desk and making a few

quick keystrokes. “Sorry, had to reply to an e-mail. At any rate, I’m sure you guys are wondering why I bothered to make this if I’m just going to be cryptic. While sharing everything I know would defeat the purpose, there are a few truths that I need to get out there before I go. These are for you guys only. If anyone else is in the room, make sure you trust them implicitly or ask them to leave. I’ll wait.”

All eyes turned to Camille, who pulled herself off the couch without a word.

“No,” Vince said, reaching over and stopping her. “I trust you. Whether you like it or not, you and Alex are pretty well lumped in with us. I think you should be here. Any objections?”

The room was silent, so they looked back at the screen and waited for Nick to continue.

“Okay, if we’re done with that, then first things first. Vince, when this is over, I want you to melt this DVD. I’m talking no remains. And don’t get lazy and smash it; you can still recover data from that if you know what you’re doing.”

Vince nodded. A moment later he wondered why he was responding to a pre-recorded message.

“Now that we’re set there, Vince, I guess I may as well start with you. I debated for a long time whether it was appropriate to tell you this or not, and in the end it was caution that led me to decide it was the right call. I don’t want someone using this information to throw you off at an inopportune moment, so it’s better to let you deal with it in advance. The father you met and talked with in Rich’s hallucination wasn’t some piece of your psyche. It was actually him. Globe entered your dream and assumed a role just like Mary. They had a conversation which she can fill you in on. We kept it from you because we weren’t sure how you would react, and to be honest, we needed to get you in fighting shape as soon as possible. It was a judgment call, and I’m sorry if you don’t agree with it.”

Vince kept his emotions far more contained than they would have expected. Two months ago this would have sent him reeling; however, with how chaotic his life had become, he’d grown exceptionally more adept at rolling with such surprises. In fact, it made a strange sort of sense when he thought about it. This would still take time to deal with, but at least he wasn’t setting the couch on fire in a breakdown.

“On the subject of Globe’s little mental visit, his talk with Mary yielded three things. A promise not to kidnap any of us, some advice to me about how to help Vince reach his potential, and a message for Alice.”

“Wait, did he say me?” Alice asked the room.

“Alice, Mary wanted to tell you this right away, but I convinced her not to. I had a pretty good hunch on what it was meant to tell you, and I knew your focus wouldn’t be on the match if I was right. If you’re mad at the delay, blame me, not Mary. She didn’t understand the point of Globe’s message, so she had no idea what she was keeping from you. Mary, I’ll pause here so you can give Alice her message.”

Alice turned to Mary, who seemed to be studying the floor with intense scrutiny. “Globe wanted me to tell you that he can’t walk into people’s dreams on his own, not like I can when Rich puts me under. He had to call in a favor from another Super to get him into Vince’s head.”

“Why on earth would I care about something like that?”

“I don’t know. He was just insistent that I tell you the name of the Super. Evidently he goes by a strange codename, but Globe was sure it would be familiar to you. The name was Abridail.”

“I’m not sure why he thought that would be familiar. Sounds like a stupid made up word. Where would I have even-” Alice’s eyes grew wide and her breathing grew rapid as the name triggered a memory from earlier in the year. There was so much confusion and anger surrounding that recollection that they nearly managed to bury all the fine details. Some, evidently, hadn’t gone as deep as she thought. Things like that name, or the man who’d used it.

“When Rich put me under at Halloween, when I had that dream about someone telling me my mom was alive and that they knew her, he told me his name was Abridail.” Alice’s hands had begun to shake without her noticing. “I never told any of you that name. I don’t think I told it to anyone at all.”

“In case Alice is having trouble remembering where the name Mary told her comes from, I assume it would match the name of the man who visited her on Halloween,” Nick said from the screen. “Otherwise there would be no reason to give it directly to her as a message. This brings us to my final topic, one that I suspect is at the center of more than even I’ve fully realized: if I’m correct, and I have ample reason to believe I am, then Alice’s mother is alive.”



Esme Stone sat with a damp cloth in her lap. It had previously contained ice to soothe a headache, now all that remained was a slightly-wet forehead and a well-soaked cloth. Memory alterations didn't usually take so much out of her, but for all his insistence that the procedure occur, Nick Campbell's brain had fought her tenaciously. She sipped a glass of ice water as Dean Blaine entered his office and took a seat. He was anxious to hear her report, but he'd still allowed her time to recover before interviewing her. Esme was thankful they'd chosen him for this position; he wore it better than many others had. She trusted him, trust both his intentions and his judgment, even without being able to read his mind. That was why she'd honored his request when she'd have refused anyone else.

"How did it go?" Blaine probed gently. His body language was relaxed; he sat back in his chair with his hands resting on the desk. Eager as he was, he forced himself to be calm for her. Things like this were why she also liked him, as well as respected him.

"It went rough, obviously," she said at last. "I've met minds more willful than his, but not often, and not for a very long time. I think I was able to get everything, but I could only manage to see bits and pieces of it."

"Such as?"

"Such as, he's taken precautions against having his mind wiped. He documented his activities in extensive summaries at the end of each semester. Names, powers, histories, everything he learned about his classmates was recorded. Even wrote one about this semester last week and messengered it to himself. He's counting on that to reconstitute his memory."

"We knew he'd try something," Blaine reminded her. "Since he figured out the memory wipe, it was inevitable he'd attempt to circumvent it. Still, written records, that's surprisingly risky."

"He used a code," she elaborated. "One he made up, one with no cypher. If he doesn't remember it, then he'll have to crack it before he can access those files."

"Great, that should buy us all of ten minutes," Blaine sighed. "Professor Pendleton appraises his cryptanalysis skills at a genius level, and I've got no inclination to disagree."

“There’s ample time before he gets to Vegas. We can have them destroyed before he arrives. It’s not like this is our first time facing such a hurdle.”

“True.” Blaine drummed his fingers on the desk without any bit of rhythm. “Let’s proceed here first. Was there anything else worth noting?”

“I’m not sure. I told you, he was able to block me from seeing all his memories of his time here.”

“Yes, though that shouldn’t have impacted the obfuscation.”

“It didn’t. No, the thing is, he chose a few spots to fight me off the hardest. Obviously I don’t know what they were, but the strange part is that he didn’t bother defending the things that most other students try to hide. Minor violations of the rules, interpersonal relationships, even a psyche delve he took over Halloween, those he gave no significant defense to keep hidden. Nothing more than his mind’s rebellion in general.”

“So whatever he wanted to keep secret, it probably wasn’t something as inane as who he has a crush on, or what bartenders in town don’t check for ID.”

“My thoughts exactly,” Esme concurred.

“That means either it was important, or he just thought it was important. Given who we’re talking about, I’m more inclined to bet on the former. I’m also sure it pertained to the HCP if he was determined to keep it from you. That damned kid, why not just come tell us?”

“Maybe he thinks we couldn’t be trusted,” Esme suggested. “He liked you and Sean, but he was also keenly aware of how people can be compromised without even knowing it. Even for someone immune to telepathy.”

“Maybe,” Blaine grudgingly admitted. Three years ago he would have called bullshit. Three years ago he also would have sworn he could trust George and Persephone with his life, let alone with his students.

“There’s one other thing I should probably mention,” Esme said, interrupting Blaine’s drifting thoughts. “When he sent his latest summary, he also sent instructions for certain pages of the older ones to be torn out and burned. He was very emphatic that no trace of them remain.”

“Well, that about cinches that then. Looks like he purposely got

himself memory wiped,” Blaine surmised.

Esme nodded. “That was my conclusion too. Sometime between winter break and now he realized a piece of information that he felt was too dangerous for anyone to have, even himself. That was probably why he protected certain memories from being seen. He didn’t want us putting together what he realized.”

“Sounds likely, but I’m surprised he’d go to such trouble, then allow someone who can see his memories access to them.”

Esme let out a chuckle. “That part was a surprise to him. He didn’t know you had someone who could view memories; he thought all we could do was erase them.”

“Too bad it didn’t give us an edge,” Blaine said. He quickly caught the possible meaning of his words and clarified. “Not that you didn’t do great work as always, Esme. I know it’s much harder for you to see protected memories than to obscure them. We all have to work in our limits, and I thank you for what you did.”

“Any time,” she replied. “For most of it.”

“Ah. I take that to mean you were successful?”

“I believe so. It wasn’t easy, but I think it’s done. You know that if the board finds out about this, even that you asked me to do it, it will be the end of both our careers?”

“You’re tenured,” Blaine reminded her, giving a gentle smile. “So I think I’d be the only one out on his ass.”

“I’m serious.”

“I know. I appreciate what you did, and I promise I wouldn’t have asked if I didn’t think it necessary.”

“Good. Try not to make a habit of this.”

Blaine held up his right hand. “Hero’s honor.”

“That you won’t ask again?”

“That I’ll try.”

“At least you’re honest,” she said, setting her damp cloth on his desk. “I’m going to bed so I can rest. Want me to have a crew of Cleaners

dispatched to Nick's casino on my way out?"

"No, I don't think that will be necessary," Blaine said. "For now, I'm going to play along. I want to see just what it is the boy has up his sleeve."

"Maybe what's up his sleeve is a plan to blackmail future Heroes with the information he's stockpiled," Esme pointed out.

"Maybe," Blaine agreed. "But I somehow doubt it. Nick is, if anything, more ambitious than that. And if I'm wrong, well... we have a contingency program for those situations as well."

## 195.

The day of departure for the sophomores of Melbrook arrived to find a strained, gloomy atmosphere had settled over the dorm. Nick's last message had left Alice and Vince with a lot to think about; both had retired that night without saying much to their fellow dorm mates. Come morning they'd all had breakfast together, although the affair had been a largely silent one. Once eating was accomplished they'd all turned their attention to finishing the last bit of packing.

Mary was nearly done when Alice knocked on her door. She opened it quickly and allowed her blonde friend to enter.

"So, I was thinking we should talk about what the plan for summer is," Alice said, walking in without any sort of formal greeting.

"I had a feeling that would come up," Mary said. She shut the door firmly and headed toward the small pile of bags sitting atop her bed. "Assuming Globe was telling the truth then there isn't any reason for me to hole up in the Adair fortress this year."

"You'd know better than anyone else if we can trust his promise. You're the only one who had a conversation with him and knew it," Alice pointed out.

"I know, and believe me when I say that is pressure I really wish I didn't have," Mary admitted. "But if I'm being honest, I don't think Globe was lying. I know he's supposed to be this master of deception and all, so it's quite possible I'm wrong-"

"But you don't think you are," Alice interrupted.

"Yeah. I can't even explain it, not rationally. I just don't think he'd go to all that trouble to deceive us."

"I trust your judgment," Alice assured her. "I guess this means you're going back to the woods then."

"That was pretty much my plan."

"Good. Do you mind if I tag along?"

Mary jerked her head back in surprise. "Beg pardon?"

Alice sat on Mary's bed and composed her thoughts for a moment before speaking. "If we assume Globe was telling the truth, then that means my mom is really alive out there somewhere. I need to process that. I need to figure out what my next step from here is. Most of all, I need to not be around my father while I do it, because if she really is out there, then he's been lying to me for my entire life."

"Alice, I'd love to have you around, but you know my outdoors life is rougher than you're accustomed to, right? I hunt my own food, gather my own firewood, walk just about everywhere. The nearest place to get any supplies is ten miles from my trailer."

"I think that sounds like exactly what I need for right now," Alice said. "Keeping busy, staying active, not letting all these thoughts overtake my ability to function. Besides, I could use a tougher environment to train in."

Mary nodded. She would have preferred a bit more solitude over summer - in fact she'd been looking forward to it - but Alice was her closest friend here. If she needed help that only Mary could provide, then Mary was going to take care of her. She would, and had, done the same when the positions were reversed.

"You should let me look over what you packed," Mary suggested. "I'll make sure you put in the sort of clothes you'll need."

\* \* \*

Ms. Daniels pulled into the parking lot near Melbrook to find one of her expected passengers already waiting for her. She took her time turning off the car and extricating herself from the driver's seat. From the look on his face and backpack slung over his shoulder, she had a hunch about what this meeting would be about, and she was not looking forward to it.

"Hey there," she greeted, pulling the taller young man in for a hug. He'd gotten thicker in the shoulders since Christmas - not much of a surprise given his age and the HCP training program. As they pulled apart she realized Vince's face had changed slightly, too. His jaw was thicker and cheekbones had shifted. He was still handsome, but he was beginning to shed the telltale signs of youth.

"Good morning, Ms. Daniels," Vince said, polite as ever. "I'm sorry to greet you so suddenly, but I needed to talk with you before you saw the others."

“You’re going to tell me that you’re not coming home with us this summer, right?”

Vince cocked his head slightly. “How did you know?”

“I got a briefing yesterday about everything that happened. They told me about your... about what happened in the match, even showed me some of the footage, and informed me that Nick was no longer in the program. I’d hoped it wouldn’t weigh on you too much, but when I saw you out here I had a pretty good idea of what was going through your head.”

“I don’t mean to be ungrateful,” Vince said. “You’ve been wonderful to me, welcoming me into your home and treating me like a part of your family. I just need to be by myself for right now. I need to deal with what I saw myself doing.”

“Vince, that wasn’t you.”

“Except that it was. I was in a hallucination, and my emotions were manipulated, but everything I did was my own reaction to it. I was, I am, capable of that kind of destruction. I didn’t even realize my ability allowed me to do some of those things. I’ve been at this for two years with ploddingly slow results, and then in five minutes Nick helped me see more of my potential than in all my classes combined. I can’t waste that. I need to start getting a grip on what my power really is, and how far I can take it. I need to train.”

“You could train in Chicago,” Ms. Daniels pointed out, even though she knew this debate was already lost. She’d married a Hero, after all. She’d seen the look of resolute determination glowing in Vince’s eyes before, and she understood that it meant his mind was set, no matter what.

“Not without endangering a lot of innocent people,” Vince pointed out. “I’m sorry, but I have to do this.”

Ms. Daniels pulled him in for another hug, this time squeezing his muscular frame. “You’re a good boy, Vince. No matter what anyone says about you, or the man who raised you, don’t you ever forget that. And once you’re done with this training of yours, I expect to see you at our house. No excuses.”

“Yes, ma’am,” Vince agreed, squeezing her back.

## Epilogue

Nicholas Campbell walked through the opulent lobby of the casino and tossed a set of car keys to a man in a red vest.

“Park it somewhere way in the back; I don’t want to see that thing again unless I need it,” he instructed. The valet scampered off without a word, efficiency incarnate. Truthfully, Nicholas would have preferred to have the car demolished, retribution for the ridiculously uncomfortable drive from the Lander campus; however, a car was a car and there was no sense in being wasteful. Maybe he’d need it again one day for a different character. He certainly hoped not. What had possessed him to decide on a Bug in the first place was a mystery, but then again, so was the vast majority of his past two years.

He made it to the elevator where Gerry was waiting. A brief nod passed between the two as they passed the polished metal doors, then they were rising through the world.

“How do you feel?” Gerry asked after a few moments.

“It’s hard to gauge. I can’t really tell a difference, but since I don’t know what I was like before the wipe, that’s not surprising.”

“I see. So is it like there’s a hole in your memories?”

“No, it’s all still there, I just can’t access it,” Nicholas told him. “How can I describe this... it’s as if all the HCP memories have been covered with fog, or ice. They’re blurry, and when I try to focus on them everything slips away.”

“Strange. Ms. Pips will want you to get some tests done just in case,” Gerry informed him.

“I assumed as much. Try and buy me a day, if you can. Did you get all the files together like I asked?”

“Pulled up from storage at your request,” Gerry said. “The last addition arrived by courier two days ago. You’ve got quite a bit of reading ahead of you.”

“At least I enjoy the author’s style,” Nicholas replied with a grin. The elevator dinged and he departed, leaving Gerry to return to his duties.



“Hey, Campbell,” Gerry called before the doors closed. “Ms. Pips wanted me to tell you that it’s good to have you back.”

“Tell her I said, ‘Good to be back’,” Nicholas replied. Once the doors shut he resumed his path down the luxurious hallway to his room. The day was young and he had a lot of work to do.

\* \* \*

Sean Pendleton - he wouldn’t think of himself as a professor again until the new school year began - was lying on his bed, staring at the television. The screen was dark, not due to any underlying technical issue, but because the power was off. He’d worked his way through more whiskey than was healthy last night, intending it to just be a few drinks to settle his brain. That plan had gone out the window when he’d read Nick’s card. It had actually been a birthday card; Sean assumed Nick had used it because the thick paper made it less likely someone like Mr. Numbers would be able to deduce the contents by feeling for a pen’s impression. That was Nick, going five miles further to obfuscate than anyone would ever consider following.

It had been a birthday card with four words written inside, below the cartoon duck wishing the recipient a “flocking good” birthday. Four words was all it had taken to send Sean’s wheels off the track. Four words that begged so much for explanation, for clarification, for verification, all of which was now impossible. He finally understood Nick’s apology. His former student was apologizing because whatever bit of information had allowed him to write those words was gone now, and Sean was stuck with only this echo of might-be truth.

The effort was grueling, but Sean slowly raised himself from his bed and walked over to his kitchen table. On it were two pieces of paper, one being the birthday card that had been such a large factor in the hangover Sean was currently dealing with. The other was the piece of paper Blaine had shown him in his cell all those months ago. The paper had a large picture taking up half the space, the rest was used for bits of information about the subject in the photograph. Sean had taken great care of it, even though now it was almost a year out of date. They grew up so fast.

He sat down at the table and pulled both papers over to him. The photo drew his attention first. It truly was amazing how much Alice looked like her mother. His half-sister had always had her own look: Shelby never resembled him and only bore a passing similarity to her fraternal twin, Blake. Both Sean and Blake had taken their features from the mother they all shared,

while Shelby took hers from her and Blake's father. The young girl in the picture definitely took after Shelby, which had just made being around her this year all the harder.

The photo went down as the card came up. Sean had poured over it already, searching for some clue, some hidden message Nick might have left him. He came up short yet again. Nothing but a cartoon duck, a bad pun, and those same four words that filled him with hope and uncertainty in nearly equal measures. Four simple words that changed the entire course of his plans:

"Shelby is still alive."

\* \* \*

Hershel and his mother made it nearly an hour into the drive before he brought up a thought that he'd been lingering on for some time.

"Mom, do you still keep in contact with any of Titan's old training partners?"

She glanced at him from the corner of her eye, always a safe driver out of habit and necessity, then replied. "I might know of a couple. Mr. Winston down the road used to do lifting exercises with your father from time to time. As for the others, well, plenty of people in our neighborhood have gifts, but few could have trained alongside Titan. Most of his partners were out of state. They had a teleporter on the team at the time, so it wasn't much of a bother."

"Oh," Hershel said, turning his eyes out the window to the passing billboards.

"I assume you wanted to do some training over the summer?"

"Yeah," Hershel admitted. "Now that Roy is finally seeing progress, he wants to make up for lost time."

"And what about you?"

"About me," Hershel echoed, turning his attention back to his mother. "This year I found out that I'm actually a part of my own power. I've spent fifteen years feeling like the unwanted tagalong in my own body. I mean, Roy is better at pretty much everything. But now, now I know I am a critical part of it, and that my effort matters. So yeah, I want to keep going, too. I want to help make both of us stronger, because I caught a glimpse of what sort of power gets you to the top of the heap, and Roy and I have serious catching up

to do.”

“I was afraid you’d say that,” Ms. Daniels sighed. “I know someone I can call when we get home. No promises, but I think he’d be willing to take on a temporary student.”

“Is he strong?”

At this Hershel’s mother let out a bark of laughter that filled the car. “Honey, he’s powerful enough to go toe to toe with your father. If he agrees to train you then the question isn’t if you’ll get stronger, the question is whether you’ll last the whole summer.”

\* \* \*

Vince crossed the line of brush and stepped out of the foliage. It had taken him most of the day to walk here, but it had been enjoyable. Of course, he could have just had Mr. Transport drop him off in this spot, but he’d needed a little physical exertion to get his head clear. Besides, he wanted to take his time.

The train tracks were the same as they always were, the metal still warped in several places from the explosion Vince now knew hadn’t claimed his father’s life. Briefly he wondered how that man had escaped, then he surmised some aspect of his power had helped him. It suddenly occurred to Vince that in all the discussion about Globe and his crimes, the silver-haired boy had never stopped to inquire what Globe’s power actually was. It seemed like a glaring oversight in review, but he’d had more pressing concerns.

Vince walked around the area slowly, not drawing attention to himself, not trying to stay hidden either. It was a longshot, he understood that, yet some part of him still demanded he come to this place. To come and see if his father would be waiting for him where their last life together ended. The chance was slim, but still as he looked around and saw nothing, he couldn’t help feeling a weight of disappointment settle in his gut.

“Well, well, looks like I owe Persephone twenty bucks,” said a familiar voice. “I bet you wouldn’t show.”

Vince turned slowly, the rock in his stomach quickly turning into magma. Twenty feet away, still in the outfit he’d been wearing on television, was the man Vince had once known as Coach George.

“Why are you here?”

“I’m the escort, if you’re willing to come,” George replied.

“Where would we be going?”

“Can’t tell you that. Can’t tell you anything. You just have to decide right now if you’re in or not.”

Vince stared at the former-teacher for several moments, then gave a small nod of his head.

“And that’s forty I’m out,” George sighed. “Oh, one more thing. You don’t get to be conscious for the trip.”

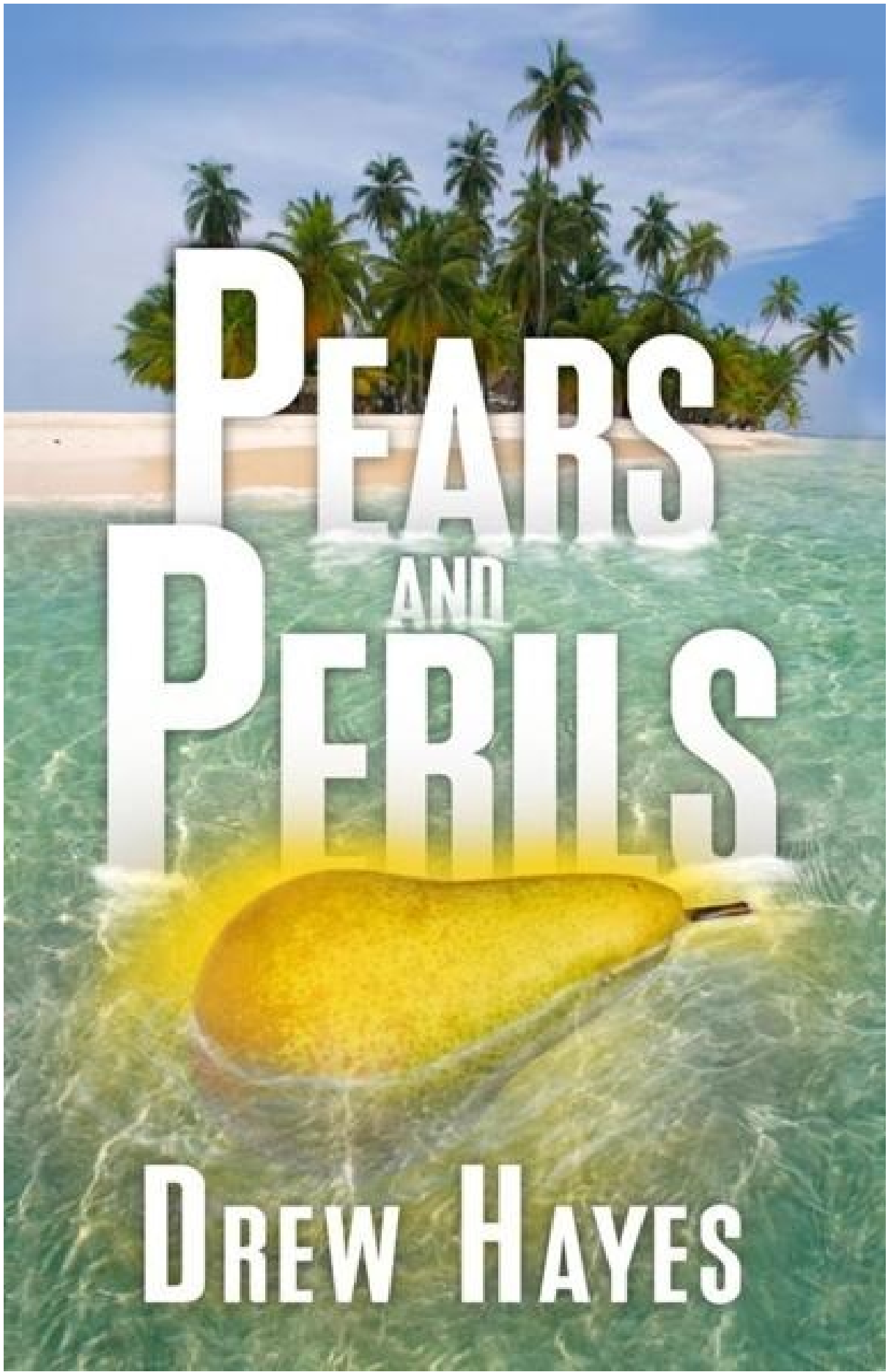
That statement set off some alarms in Vince’s head. He reached for the energy inside himself, but before he could summon even a flame, Vince’s vision went blurry and he felt his body grow weak. In a span of seconds it was all he could do to stay standing, and moments later even that was impossible. His consciousness abandoned him as he tumbled toward the ground.

A pair of strong arms caught him before he could bash his head open against a rock; George had crossed the distance between them as soon as Vince had shown signs of dizziness. He set the boy on the ground carefully then pulled the small dart Vince hadn’t even noticed out of the boy’s shoulder. That done, he produced a cell phone from his pocket and punched in a few numbers.

“Hey,” he called gruffly over the phone. “It’s George. I’ve got him, so get my ride over here.”

Almost instantly a crackling sphere of white light appeared a few feet away from him. George closed his phone and hefted the muscular form of Vince Reynolds onto his shoulder. He stepped through the light without any fuss, and moments later it vanished, leaving only a scent of electrical discharge in the air.

**And now, a free sample chapter from another Drew  
Hayes novel:**



# PEARS AND PERILS

DREW HAYES

## 1.

“Tucker! My office! Now!” Mr. Henderson didn’t even bother to make his already thunderous voice seem civil. Everyone within the distance of his shout, which is to say everyone within a forty cubicle range, could guess that whatever Clint Tucker was being called in for, it likely ended with a boot up his ass: likely a boot with a pink slip attached.

Mr. Henderson stood in the door of his office, his impressive bulk nearly blotting out the silver-haired gentleman behind him. Dr. Caruthers (he didn’t get a Ph.D. in economics to be called Mr. Caruthers thank-you-very-much) stood silently in the shadow of the larger man, content to represent himself physically rather than vocally. His physical representation was quite excellent at that: a tall, lean figure in a suit that cost more than the car any given person on this floor drove. His face was placid and if one didn’t know better, one would have thought him to have a look of kindness. Those who were more informed thought of it as the expression an alligator wears as it drifts through the swamp. It was an expression that conveyed a willingness to wait, but only until there was prey within striking distance.

“Tucker!” Mr. Henderson’s voice roared through the office once more.

Slowly, as if he were savoring every moment he still had in the fluorescent environment, Clint Tucker rose from his cube and began plodding toward the office. He was slightly taller than most of the employees, with a shock of light brown hair and muddy chocolate eyes. The suit he wore was off the rack, the kind of garment Dr. Caruthers would buy for his butler, only to give himself something to chuckle about. Clint was a curious fellow; he always ambled where others rushed and never seemed to sweat the frequent rumors of layoffs swirling about the office.

“You wanted me, Boss?” Clint asked evenly as he stared at the purple vein bulging in the front of Mr. Henderson’s bald head. It swelled and pulsed whenever Mr. Henderson was angry. Once upon a time he’d covered it up with hats and toupees, but over the years Mr. Henderson had come to embrace his vein for the motivational tool it was.

“We need to have a little chat.” Mr. Henderson pronounced ‘chat’ the way mean-spirited judges pronounced maximum sentences.

“Cool.” Clint slid past the larger man and took the nearest unoccupied seat in the contemporary office. There was a large oak desk, motivational posters decorating the walls, and it was filled with natural light from a window with a gorgeous view of the city. Mr. Henderson had fought, backstabbed, and kissed all manner of ass to procure this office. Publicly he’d say his children were his pride and joy. After a few scotches, though, he could be pressed to admit it was this office.

Mr. Henderson shut the door firmly and took his time working around the desk to his high-backed leather chair. He sat with a considerable thump and looked at the young man across from him. Silence hung in the air as the two older men stared down the youthful face in front of them. Clint was barely twenty-four, hardly more than a baby as far as these two business veterans were concerned. He had his whole life ahead of him, or would have if circumstances were different.

“Clint,” Mr. Henderson began softly, switching up his vocal tactics to keep the boy on his toes. “We’re here to talk about Project Jefferson.”

Clint nodded solemnly. He’d been under no illusions that this could be about anything different.

“As you know, the program was supposed to create a centralized system into which people could feed all of their e-mail addresses and then access them from a single point. Now, when you gave us the go ahead to begin beta-testing, we discovered an unfortunate side effect of the system. Would you care to venture what that is?”

“It deletes all of their e-mail?”

“It deletes all of their e-mail!” Mr. Henderson shouted, slamming his fist on the desk before realizing that Clint had actually replied. “Wait... you knew?”

“It seemed like it was a possibility when I looked at the code. But the people at the top wanted us to hit their deadline so I rolled the dice.” Clint nodded unapologetically toward Dr. Caruthers. The doctor was head of the Engineering and Development department despite his utter lack of knowledge in anything technical beyond checking stocks on his phone. “When people who are clueless are made into leaders, there are bound to be mistakes.”

Dr. Caruthers felt his eyebrows go up in surprise. Who in the hell did this whelp think he was?

“Now see here, young man, I happen to have a doctorate in economics from a very prestigious university-”

“Tell me the difference between Python and Perl. Tell me how long it takes an average programmer to write one hundred lines of code. Tell me what a reasonable deadline for developing software like this is. I know you can’t do the last one, you already fucked that up, didn’t you?” There was no anger in Clint’s voice, no fire being verbally released. He talked calmly, as though he were stating obvious facts like, “The sun is hot” or “Coffee wakes you up.”

Dr. Caruthers’ mouth opened and closed several times, his mind trying to wrap itself around the insolence that had just been thrust at him. He was accustomed to being on the offense; the idea of one of his grunts speaking to



him in such a way confounded his strategies so much that he found himself trapped in a moment of inaction.

Fortunately, Mr. Henderson suffered no such dilemma.

“I will hear no more of this!” Mr. Henderson roared, rising from his desk like the licking fires of hell. “Dr. Caruthers is an outstanding leader who has always valued the opinions of his employees. If you had problems with the deadline, it’s your own fault for not coming to me or him with them. The one who made the mistake was you, and we’re throwing you on your ass for it. I want you out of my goddamned office in the next five minutes or I’ll break out the pepper spray we keep for dealing with protestors!”

“Whatever you say,” Clint replied with a shrug. He headed out of the office and paused at his desk only long enough to pick up a pen he’d brought from home. Clint didn’t keep any personal items at his desk; it would be a silly practice given his line of work. There were a few consolatory nods from co-workers: had he been around longer they would have stopped him and found a place to meet up to throw a good-bye party. He hadn’t been around that long, though. He never was.

Back in the office, Dr. Caruthers at last found his voice. “I cannot believe such an important project was handed over to that impudent little bastard.”

Mr. Henderson nodded his agreement. “It was a real disappointment, especially given how outstanding his references were. When he first showed up his letters of recommendation were so glowing I thought they were fake. That’s why I kicked the decision up to you.”

Dr. Caruthers felt a scathing jab wither on his tongue. He’d nearly forgotten that he’d been the one to approve Clint Tucker’s hiring. That complicated things somewhat. He couldn’t throw Mr. Henderson to the wolves when it was the Caruthers’ name on all the documentation. Well, Tucker had admitted his own folly in front of two witnesses and been summarily discharged. The shareholders would have undoubtedly preferred a scapegoat that was higher on the food chain for this snafu; however, Dr. Caruthers was confident he could work with what he had.

“It’s surprising he was able to do so much damage, given that he was just brought on to help the project meet deadline. I mean, he was barely here longer than a week.”

“A lot can happen in a week,” Mr. Henderson replied.

“So it seems,” Dr. Caruthers agreed. “I suppose that will be all today. Get your people busy on a fix for Project Jefferson. I want it by...” Dr. Caruthers hesitated. “Well, how long do you think it will take them to complete?”

Mr. Henderson smiled confidently. "I am positive they can get it done in four weeks."

"Excellent," Dr. Caruthers said. "Have it ready in two."

\* \* \*

A young couple walked happily along the stone path, taking in the sights of the island as they adjusted to the tropical heat. Kenowai was a tourist mecca, offering inclusive resorts or secluded getaways, depending on a traveler's preferences. Ahead of the couple, a tan man with dark hair and rippling muscles carried their bags. They hadn't bothered to ask, but the fellow was a native named Mano. He'd worked at this particular hotel for many years and carried the bags of many couples. A few times a year he'd also carried some new bride with panicked regrets into the highest levels of carnal bliss, but that was a dangerous hobby and one best observed only in small amounts. On the whole, he worked here because the owners were nice, the visitors cheerful, and on the rare occasion when he got to work the pool bar, it meant he didn't have to spend the whole afternoon sweating.

They drew close to their building, a several-story complex that looked out of place against Kenowai's unspoiled vegetative scenery. They were nearly to the double doors when Mano held up his hand to stop them. The couple obliged, unsure if there was some additional check-in procedure or quaint island tradition they needed to observe. Instead, they stood still as a cat walked across the path in front of them. It was the color of midnight across its entire body, except for the tail, which had a tip that was gold as sunlight dipped in honey. The cat paid them no mind as it skulked along, its eyes fixed on the world before it.

"Sorry, folks," Mano said with just enough accent to be charming. "Got to give right of way to the King of the Island."

The newlyweds stared at him for a moment, then began laughing at such an adorable concept. They went in and got their room keys while Mano set down their bags and noted what an appreciable bottom the woman possessed. He already had a feeling this was the kind of day that could end in trouble, but Mano had stayed out of trouble for a long time now and that was dangerous, too. Mano was firm in the belief that you had to visit trouble every now and then, like a needy relative, to keep it satiated. If you didn't visit it then it was likely to get lonely and come looking for you.

Outside, the cat came to a dune that overlooked the beach and took a seat. He stared out at the ocean, dreaming of all the fish that flew beneath its waves. The cat's name was Sprinkles, and the reason for that is a story within itself. The humans thought they were joking when they called him King of Kenowai. They didn't know it, but they weren't. Sprinkles was a cat and a

king and one thing more, and it was this third part that nagged him as he gazed out from his dune. Something was gathering, some confluence of events that would lead to his island. He wondered what it would be, though the wonder was less of a worry than the natural curiosity inherent to all felines. After all, Sprinkles was sure he could protect his island from any threat.

You see, while most cats were certain they were of divine blood, if not outright gods, Sprinkles was an aberrant piece of data in the equation. Oh, he had the same certainty as the others that he was cat, king, and godling, but Sprinkles was different.

Sprinkles was right.

\* \* \*

Clint sat in an Irish pub, nursing a beer that was dark as a storm cloud and twice as angry. Normally he would be sitting on a stool at the bar; however, the gentleman soon to be joining him insisted on a booth so they were less visible. If Clint had been pressed, he might have offered up a theory that working to be less visible only made you more interesting to look at. It didn't matter, though: the company policy said that the client was always right. This was less out of a desire to provide excellent customer service and more from the desire to be able to claim blamelessness should the client's preferred meeting method end in discovery. Not that what the company did was illegal, per se: merely frowned upon ethically.

A figure in a raincoat and a hat slid through the door of the pub, keeping its eyes to the floor and moving quickly so as not to draw attention. Of course everyone noticed it, but when they realized it was neither a deranged shooter nor a beautiful woman, attention quickly waned. There was a groan from the booth's boards as the figure settled its sizable heft across from Clint.

"You... are amazing," came a strangled voice from the poorly-concealed face. "You saved my job. My whole department."

"It's what we do," Clint said simply. "I'm glad it worked. Did you pad your schedule this time?"

There was an adamant nodding of the mystery man's head, one shake so vigorous it caused the hat to slip and nearly reveal the purple vein that bulged against the bald head. "I told him four, he gave us two, which is one more than we should need."

"Sounds like things are good then," Clint said. "Just be careful what you authorize for beta-testing in the future. The businesses who lost their e-mails were howling for blood over lost orders and documentation. Even we can only do so much."

“I understand.” From within the jacket the figure produced a thin envelope and slid it across the table. “Your severance pay, as specified in your contract. To be honest, I’m surprised they agreed to it when they hired you.”

“If your references are fantastic enough, they’ll do anything to get you. Speaking of which, I trust we can count on you for a letter of recommendation and an amazing review when you get called?”

“Of course. Your company held up your end, I’ll hold up mine.”

“I think that’s everything then,” Clint said simply. “Would you like a beer?”

“No, thank you. I’ve spent the last month certain I was going to get fired. I’m spending tonight at home, celebrating with the wife.”

“Understandable.” Clint watched as the large man worked his way free of the booth and hurriedly shuffled out the door. He took another sip of his beer and looked at the check in the envelope. It was all there, of course. Corporations were always fastidious about contract adherence. That was part of what made a position like Clint’s possible. His official title was Freelance Consultant for Withersby Positional Solutions Incorporated. They specialized in bringing in employees just before bad news became known to the higher-ups in a company, and then proceeding to take the blame for whatever that particular brand of catastrophe entailed.

To put it simply: Clint Tucker was a professional scapegoat.

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# **The Uninteresting and Unadventurous Tales of Fred, The Vampire Accountant**

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## About the Author



Drew Hayes is an aspiring author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

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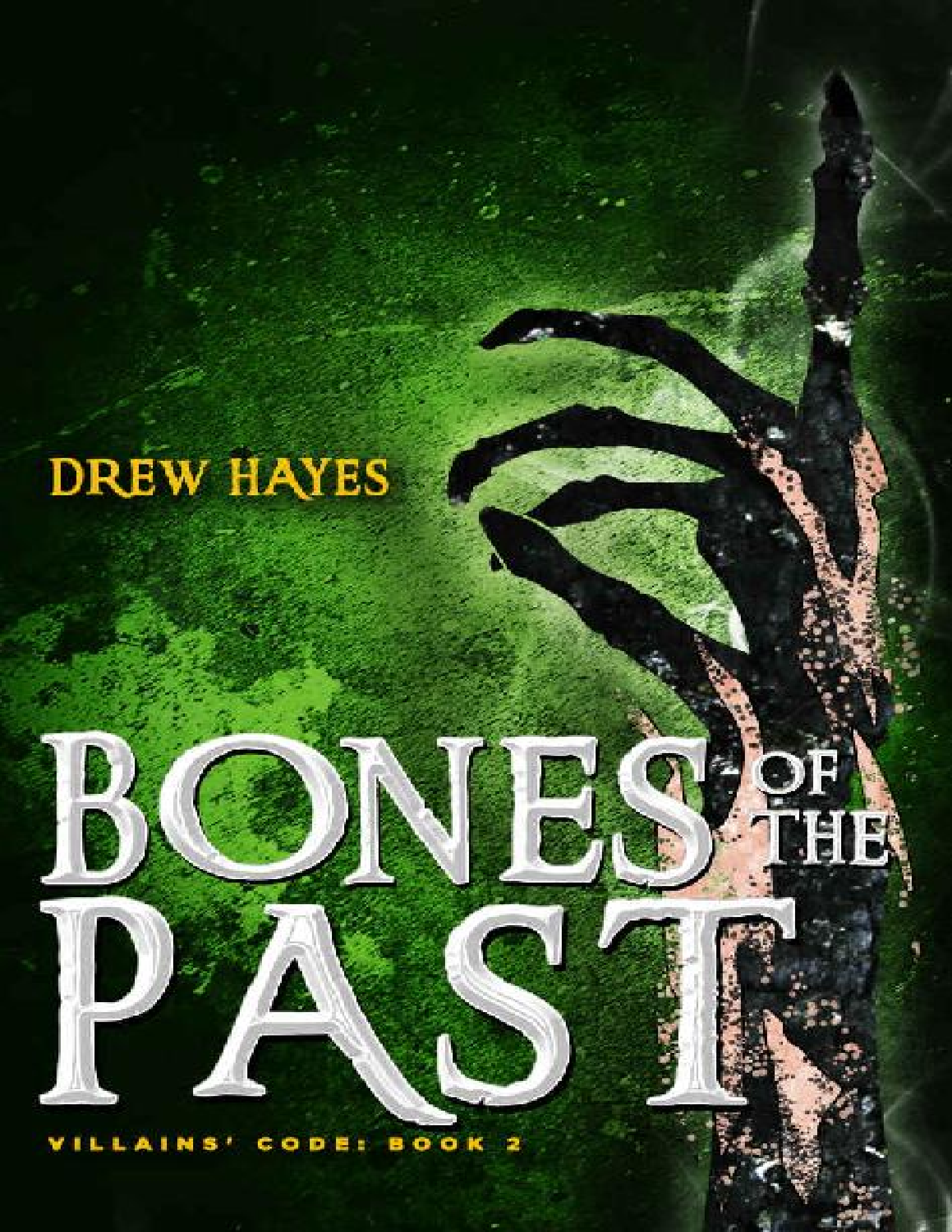
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DREW HAYES

# BONES OF THE PAST

VILLAINS' CODE: BOOK 2

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# BONES OF THE PAST

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## Villains' Code: Book 2

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DREW HAYES

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## Prologue

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“Would you hurry up already? I’m not missing this because you couldn’t be bothered to leave the lab. Chloe and I *will* go up to the roof without you.”

Tori let out a long, exasperated breath and cursed her past self’s naiveté. When she’d been setting up her new lab, tucked away in what was supposed to be three underground personal parking garages (which had undergone serious reconstruction and retrofitting) beneath her apartment building, the idea of an intercom had seemed like a stroke of brilliance. This way, Chloe and Beverly could easily reach her if something important came up without having to run down and potentially alert Tori’s security system. Only after everything was put in place did it occur to her that perhaps she should have put in a function to mute them when the need arose.

Dropping her tools onto her workbench, Tori walked over to the intercom and held down the formerly white button, stained now with grease and oil from the weeks she’d spent toiling away down in her lair. “I’m almost done. Chill the hell out. It’s not even supposed to start until nine.”

“That’s an estimate, and you know it. Nobody can be sure exactly when they’ll arrive.”

Personally, Tori had her doubts about such a statement. While it was true that the local news had been reporting on the impending phenomenon for the last two weeks—ever since someone at the Alliance of Heroic Champions first noticed the anomaly—many people had actually known about it several days prior to the announcement. Doctor Mechanial had sent out an email to all the scattered guild members, which self-deleted immediately after being read, cautioning them to the impending threat.



Well, perhaps less cautioning, and more telling them to make sure to stay out of whatever it was that went down. There were more than a few Guild of Villainous Reformation members who couldn't resist a good slugfest, and this sure as hell had the potential to be one. Still, no one—at least no one still with the guild after Balaam's uprising—was going to disobey a direct order from Doctor Mechaniacal. He'd given the alert, and the arrival time, well before the capes had even admitted to knowing anything was going on. If he said they'd get here at nine, Tori was inclined to believe him.

“Give me five more minutes. I'm working on something special.” Tori released the button and turned her attention back to her current project. For once, it wasn't the pieces of a red and black meta-suit splayed out on the giant workstation she'd set up in her first few days here. That was an ongoing project, one that would never truly be completed, though she had managed to finish an overhaul and upgrade along with all the repairs it had needed after the city-wide brawl. No, for now, her attention was on three sets of what had once been welder's goggles, though they were barely recognizable as such under all the gadgetry and tech Tori had added to them.

Much as Beverly might complain, she'd see it was a worthwhile use of time when Tori brought the ocular bad boys back to the apartment. These sorts of shows didn't come along very often, and she wanted to see every last detail. Besides, this project had made for a nice diversion, something to take her mind off what was coming.

Exciting as the night's festivities would be, they had nothing on what was coming over the weekend. Now *that* was something to be on time for.



Much as Ivan would have preferred to be with his children, Janet and her husband Juan had taken them out of the city, a decision that Ivan wholeheartedly endorsed. He had ample confidence in the AHC, especially now that Lodestar was once more at her post, but that didn't mean things still couldn't go sideways without warning. Better his children be far from the danger, somewhere away from all the chaos and madness of things to come. It had been hard enough to accept his youngest, Beth, acquiring

meta-human abilities; the last thing he needed was her brother Rick ending up in the same boat.

Instead of watching the show at his townhouse—a poor replacement for the suburban home that was still being rebuilt—Ivan had taken advantage of his decades-old friendship with a billionaire and decided to watch from Wade Wyatt's downtown penthouse. This was partially because Wade always kept high-end food a mere phone call away, but also due to a lingering sense of worry. If something bad did happen, he'd prefer to have his old friend, Doctor Mechaniacal, at his side. Between the two of them, they could easily make the difference in a fight, should the need arise. While it was hardly an ideal situation, especially for a pair of semi-retired supervillains, the fact remained that they lived on this planet just as much as everyone else. A threat to Earth was a threat to their home, and they were not men who took such dangers kindly.

"Ivan, please calm down. I can see you gripping the armrest of that chair. Any moment now you'll snap it clean off, and it was made custom for this apartment." Wade dropped down next to Ivan, staring out one of the floor-to-ceiling windows that wrapped around his entire penthouse. They, like Wade himself, were deceptive in appearance. Each was fitted with a wide array of technological marvels, allowing them to zoom like a lens, go dark, serve as television screens, withstand a rocket launcher, and probably do all manner of other tricks Ivan had yet to witness.

As for Wade, he seemed as unworried as usual, relaxing in khakis and a polo, his thinning copper hair unstyled. The gentle smile Wade wore almost hid the brilliance of the mind behind it, that of the genius inventor who had won infamy as Doctor Mechaniacal, the man in the meta-suit that was powerful enough to challenge all but the strongest of capes. That was a long time ago, however. Nowadays, he was merely a billionaire tech mogul who led a secret guild of villains who worked smarter than the common criminal.

Perhaps things hadn't changed as much as Ivan thought.

"Sorry." Ivan released his grip on the armrest; there were finger indents still visible in the leather. "The timing just has me worried. We've kept our heads down for months, and now, suddenly, days before we're about to put things back in order, this happens. The timing just seems... suspicious."

"Come on, Ivan. You've been around long enough to know how these things go," Wade replied. "Where meta-humans are concerned, events and

forces tend to pile together. Confluences are the best example, but they're far from the only one. Hell, it happens to regular people, too. Where do you think the saying 'when it rains, it pours' comes from?"

"I still don't like it." Ivan reached over to the table and helped himself to a handful of grilled shrimp. Wade had called up quite a spread for just the two of them. Then again, given how much Ivan had stress-eaten already, he might have gotten the exact right amount of food. That was Wade—brilliant and calculating, down to the last detail. Oddly, that thought made Ivan feel better. If the smartest person he knew wasn't worried about tonight, then maybe it was okay to relax.

"What you don't like is being on the sidelines," Wade told him. "Tori pulled you back in, and now you're hankering to throw some punches and make your strength known. Even if you know you aren't needed, you'd still prefer to be active than to watch from a luxury suite."

Much as Ivan wanted to deny that possibility, he couldn't. Wade was right. He'd gone back into battle, had remembered what it was like to be his full self for the first time in years, and now he was having to shake the craving all over again, like a relapsing addict.

"There's nothing to worry about. The AHC is doing a full-court press, a real show of force. After Apollo's attempted revolt and the ensuing fight with us, they're all over this sort of PR opportunity." Wade reached out and helped himself to a crab cake from the pile on a nearby table. "And even if that weren't true, Lodestar is going to be there. Do I really need to remind *you* that she's more than enough to handle nearly any threat? Add in Professor Quantum being back and Quorum getting off the sidelines, and the fight almost seems unfair."

Those three, the Champions' Congress, overseers of the AHC, were indeed a team that was not to be tested. Ivan knew it well; he'd experienced it firsthand. All the same, he'd feel much better when this evening was said and done.

Until then, he tried to force himself to relax and focus on the food.



"—and that about *wraps* things up!"

Though he groaned inwardly, Cyber Geek merely smiled for the cameras as Hat Trick posed next to the would-be muggers, bound now in the multicolored scarves she'd summoned from her sleeves. Hat Trick—Lucy, when she was out of costume—was kind, dedicated, brave, and trustworthy. Cyber Geek—Donald, when he didn't have to dress up like the superhero he still sometimes felt he wasn't—valued her as a teammate and liked her as a friend. However, she was an adamant fan of putting puns in her banter, and no amount of gentle coaching or careful suggestion would deter her from making those quips.

At least there weren't many reporters out tonight. They, like most of Ridge City, were busy covering the much-bigger news: eyes to the sky, waiting with bated breath to see how things played out. For his part, Donald would have loved to be watching things unfold with the rest of the citizens. But he wasn't a citizen. He was Cyber Geek, superhero of the Alliance of Heroic Champions, and that meant there was work to be done.

With all the big names and powerful capes occupied by the impending event, it had fallen to the newer recruits to make sure the streets stayed safe tonight. More than a few crooks had gotten the idea to take advantage of the distraction and pull off some capers. Already Cyber Geek and Hat Trick had foiled three muggings, two robberies, and a drunken man trying to make love to a post box. Medley and Cold Shoulder, the other two members of their team also known as Ren and Irene when out of costume, were a few blocks over, busting up a bar brawl. That wouldn't take long; one look at Medley and everyone sober enough to process fear would stop short. A living chimera composed of over a half dozen animals, including a tiger-like head, scales, fur, claws, and a sharp tail, Medley was a walking reminder that natural human defenses weren't at the top of the food chain. Cold Shoulder, with her ice powers, was equally dangerous, though she didn't look it. Cyber Geek pitied the poor bastard who tried to take a swing at her; Cold Shoulder was a big fan of shock and awe.

Originally, they'd planned to work the night as a team, but the need for capes had forced them to split off and spread themselves thin. Cyber Geek was shocked at how much crime there was; he'd lived in Ridge City all his life and had thought of it as one of the safest towns in existence. Maybe it was the excitement—or the fear—about what was coming. Maybe the whispers he'd heard in the AHC halls were true, and that guild they'd fought had kept the low-level crooks too scared to cause much trouble.

Whatever the reason, it didn't matter; not tonight. What counted was keeping people safe, just like the stronger capes would be doing in the sky.

Still, it was a pity. If he'd been given the choice, been allowed to exist as Donald rather than Cyber Geek for the evening, he might have tried to watch things unfold with Tori. They hadn't gotten to talk much over the last few weeks, with Donald getting more responsibility from the AHC and Tori being promoted out of her intern-level work. Keeping connections with normal people was more difficult than he'd expected, but he wanted to keep trying all the same. Important as Cyber Geek was, he couldn't let Donald fade away completely.

Static buzzed in his ear communicators as new orders came in. Someone was trying to break into an antiques store ten blocks away. Hat Trick nodded—she'd heard the same thing he had—and, with a quick throw of her arm, sent another multicolored scarf shooting out from her sleeve. The fabric wrapped itself around a nearby building's ledge and just like that, she was off, swinging through the air. There were plenty of people who'd have thought finding an enchanted starter magician's kit made for a lame power, but Hat Trick had managed to prove she could be just as useful as someone like Medley, even if she lacked the brute force.

For his travel, Cyber Geek reached into the digital display he now always had with him and pulled out a gigantic blue boot large enough for a human to stand inside. It was an item from *Jump Jump Jones*, a video game from childhood that offered some strange, but useful, travel options. Getting inside the boot, Cyber Geek launched up from the ground, easily clearing twenty feet in the first bound, before landing unharmed on the street below.

There were more efficient ways to travel, when the need was dire, but he'd discovered that few things made the same impression on criminals as a massive shoe dropping down from the sky. After all, Cold Shoulder didn't have a patent on shock and awe.



Chloe and Beverly were already on the roof by the time Tori sprinted through the door, three sets of goggles hanging on her arm. From the top of their apartment building, they could see the other nearby roofs crowded with dozens of watchers using telescopes and cameras. Luckily, most of the

people who lived in their building were the type to prefer viewing live news footage rather than standing in the slightly chilly late-Summer air. That left the trio alone, which was how they preferred it, anyway.

“About time! You know it’s five minutes to nine,” Beverly chastised. She was tall, with piercing green eyes that shifted color when Beverly turned into one of her several dragon forms. Of course, when that was the case, she went by Bahamut, as no villain worth their salt used their own name in a caper.

“Yeah, I cut it close, but at least I brought party favors.” Tori held up the goggles, handing a pair each to Beverly and Chloe, keeping a set for herself.

“I’ll be the one to ask: what the heck are these?” Chloe turned them over in her pale hands before slipping the goggles past her short, bleached-white hair and onto her face. She looked a tad like an owl who’d gotten really into steampunk as she twisted and turned, staring up at the night sky.

Tori walked over and gently lifted Chloe’s hand up to the side of the goggles, where a dial could be felt. “Specialized watching devices. I figured we’d want to get a great view of the show. If you tweak this part here, you should be able to adjust the scope and focus of your lenses. Don’t worry about glares from the ships or powers: I added enough neutralizing light filters that you could chart the stars at noon. Actually, daytime sky-gazing might be a fun use for these.” Moving Chloe’s finger across the dial, Tori heard her roommate gasp in surprise as the stars above them came into sharp focus.

“Holy shit. Now I feel bad about yelling at you to hurry.” Beverly had donned her own pair after watching the demonstration and was currently looking up into the night. “These are awesome.”

“Apology accepted, because hell yes, they are.” Tori slipped on her own goggles, but didn’t zoom in just yet. Despite her faith in Doctor Mechaniac’s calculations, the location of arrival could shift slightly in response to the AHC’s presence, so she wanted to keep a wide view until then. “We’ll be able to see the purple in Lodestar’s eyes with these.”

Before anyone could question the truth of that statement, it happened.

The ship burst into view above Ridge City, clearly alien from the first glance. It was oddly shaped in such a way that looking at it too long made Tori’s head start to hurt, but it wasn’t as large as she’d been expecting. Maybe that was why it had managed to get this close before being noticed.

All around them, in the streets and on the rooftops, people yelled in excitement and pointed to the sky. Even in Ridge City, visitors from outer space were not a common occurrence. It had been over a decade since the attempted Cernovian invasion, and at least five years since the cape known as Cresscriss arrived, fleeing his doomed planet. In the time since, they had yet to encounter any more alien presences—until this ship had been seen barreling toward Earth.

Tori was about to adjust her dial, but paused just long enough to check her watch first. Nine on the dot. Doctor Mechaniacal had been right yet again, not that she was surprised. Her respect for the legendary tech-based villain was second only to that for Ivan, the man who had once been feared across the world as the monstrous Fornax. That respect came not from admiration at what he'd built, though, but rather from the mentor he'd been to her when she first joined the guild. Ivan had done his best to shape her education and keep her alive. Without him, she might never have become the meta-suit-wearing villain known as Hephaestus.

And now, she was getting the chance to watch someone Ivan respected—and feared—in action. Twisting her dial, Tori searched the skies for the signature glow of the world's most powerful cape.



The Grzzniltan ship broke easily through the atmosphere, and the city below came into view. From behind the seat, the pilot could hear its navigator listing off information about the elements in the air. They'd have to do some extensive testing first, but remote scouts had indicated that this place might be perfect for terraforming. True, it would wipe out the native inhabitants; however, that was of little concern. These strange creatures with their vulnerable skin and primitive minds—they couldn't even travel between the stars. Cleansing them would be a kindness, really, saving them from their own ignorance.

It happened suddenly and with almost no warning, save for the streak of light that shot up from the ground below. The entire ship halted in midair, sending the pilot flailing. It grabbed onto the console with its tentacles in an effort to stay balanced. If they hadn't slowed in preparation for landing,

such a violent stop would have turned it and the crew into pulp on the nearest wall.

The others were already scrambling, trying to understand what could have stopped them so instantly. It should have been impossible, but perhaps the native creatures had better defenses than they'd expected.

The large screen at the front of the room lit up with a new image, one much smaller than the picture of the ground below. Floating in the sky, glowing like the heart of a star, was a female creature similar to the native animals the Grzzniltan probes had reported in early scouting endeavors. Except that species didn't fly, or glow, or stop entire spaceships with a single one of their five-digit tentacles. Hands, these creatures called them. But of course, that was impossible. Even the mighty Wrexwren warriors, renowned for their raw power, couldn't halt an entire ship in midair. It was some sort of technology; that was the only explanation.

"Hi there!" She spoke in odd noises, yet moments later, the proper grunts and gloomfs reached the pilot's ears. "My name is Lodestar. I hope this translator is working right. Cresscriss said your ship was Grzzniltan and tried to whip something up so we could talk."

Cresscriss? A Paldomian name, yet there were no more Paldomians in the universe. They'd been wiped out, a necessary stepping stone on the road to others' progress. Was this creature lying, or had some truly escaped?

"Anyway, I wanted to let you know that this is Earth, and if you've come here seeking safety, peace, trade, or any sort of diplomatic relations, we welcome you with open arms. Should that be the case, we'd be happy to escort you to a safe landing site and open discussions."

As the Earth native spoke, more of her kind came into view. One wore glass in front of his eyes and a long white coat, his whole body sparking with blue energy as he floated in midair. Another had simple clothes, save for a silver belt around his waist that seemed to be keeping him aloft. Looking at that one, he seemed wrong, like too many creatures piled into a single section of space and time. Others rose from the ground, wearing all manner of shapes and colorful garb.

The pilot's navigator was shouting, trying to get the pilot's attention. It couldn't imagine what was so important; they clearly needed to wipe away these pests first.

Still, listening was an integral part of being in command, so the pilot oozed over to the navigator and looked at the screen. What it saw made two



of his nine fluid sacks skip pulsations. The navigator had pulled up a program designed to sweep for any dangerous or profitable energy sources, and what stood before their ship was unfathomable. That much power, condensed into such minute forms... it boggled all sense of logical. Many of these creatures were dangerous, but the three at the forefront were a class of their own. As for the one who had seemingly stopped their vessel... the readings from her went beyond such primitive concepts as danger.

“We like to think of ourselves as a friendly planet,” the human woman continued, unfazed by the effort of holding an entire spaceship suspended. “We’ve got some extraterrestrial folks who can vouch for that. But you should also know, we’re not a species who likes to be stepped on or subjugated. If there were any Cernovians still around, I’d tell you to ask them. So, if you’re here for peace, let me reiterate that we welcome you.”

The creature—Lodestar she had called herself—paused long enough to move her arm. As she did, the entire ship shifted, dispelling any doubt about what had halted them mid-flight. It was a short display, but a potent one all the same. Once she’d finished, Lodestar resumed her speech.

“But if you’ve come here to cause trouble, then you should know that we are plenty capable of making that ourselves. And we would be *more* than happy to share.”



Cheers burst from around them as the ship rose back into the sky, quickly fading from view for all those without telescopes or goggles whipped together by a tech-genius. Tori, Beverly, and Chloe all sat on the roof for some while, watching it vanish back into the space between the stars from whence it came. Interesting as it would have been to access a new species of alien thoughts, culture, and technology, Cresscriss had already made the public aware that Grzzniltans tended to be opportunists and cowards, so they’d most likely flee when faced with a species capable of fighting back.

“I like to think I’ve seen my fair share of shit, but that was still pretty damn cool.” Beverly yanked her goggles off and tried to hand them to Tori, who shook her head.

“Keep them. Maybe we’ll come up here and do some stargazing. Or you can be a perv and watch that all-dude running club that goes by here every

afternoon.”

“Runners? No thanks. I like my men with more muscle than that. Stargazing sounds fun, though.” Beverly carefully tucked the goggles into one of her pockets and let out a sigh. “You know, there was a time in my life where watching capes send a spaceship packing would have been the most amazing part of my year. But now, all I can think about is this weekend.”

“You and me both,” Tori agreed.

“Personally, I can’t wait for this weekend,” Chloe said. “With you two out of the house, I’m going to do a terrible movie marathon and try out some new casserole recipes. I’ll save the best one for when you get home.”

There wasn’t much that could top a preemptively-foiled alien invasion; however, for them, one such event loomed bright on the horizon. In a few days’ time, the thing they’d been anticipating for months would finally arrive.

This Saturday, the guild’s new headquarters would officially open, and with that, they would begin their work as true members.

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## Chapter 1

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When everything was said and done, the central blame for the day's events—and all that came about as a result of them—could be placed squarely on the aliens who were stopped before they ever touched down. True, they fled the moment they were met by much of the AHC (particularly Lodestar, Professor Quantum, and Quorum), but they also provided a huge shot of excitement on a Tuesday evening. Even after their departure, Tori had stayed up with Beverly and Chloe for several hours, talking about the stars and the potential mysteries beyond them. While they, like the rest of the world, were aware that extraterrestrials existed, not much more was known than that. The few refugees who'd found a place on Earth had either known little outside their own worlds or had been unwilling to part with such information. In a way, that was a blessing, for the uncertainty of what lay beyond the dark skies was as important as the twinkling stars themselves.

Of course, a night up late talking with her friends meant that Tori was sleep-deprived and grouchy, even by her standards. It didn't help that she'd been pulling all-nighters for the week before, working overtime to make certain her meta-suit was fully operational before the guild meeting. Neither she nor Beverly were entirely sure what to expect, but if Tori had learned one thing during her apprenticeship, it was to always be prepared to meet any challenge.

"You look rough." Ivan had barely glanced up as she set the stack of files on his desk, yet he wasn't too absorbed to snap off the quick remark.

"Fuck you, too." Tori glanced around quickly to make sure no one had overheard. Though she was supposed to be Ivan's niece—a necessary bit of

subterfuge left over from when she'd lived over his garage—there was a limit to how glib she was allowed to be in the office. Thankfully, no one was walking by Ivan's door right then, so the remark remained their secret.

“Cute. But I'm serious. You need to pull yourself together. We've got a big meeting this afternoon, and you're going to be around the upper management. This will be their first time seeing you as an executive coordinator instead of an intern; I want you to make a good impression.” He was still looking at his desk, filling out forms without so much as a moment of hesitation between his pen strokes. Fornax was a powerful beast, Tori had seen that firsthand, but Ivan Gerhardt's capacity for multitasking was a feat she still found rather astounding.

Unfortunately, he was also right. While the title of Executive Coordinator really meant that she just did the same work she had as Ivan's assistant for several other managers, it had come with a bump in pay and put her on a solid career track. According to the development plan Vendallia Industries had made her fill out, within two years she'd be on track for an HR job, and after that, she could move into management herself. Granted, Tori didn't know how long she'd actually need to keep this cover job going, but until she had enough capital from respectable sources to start her own tech firm, she needed to appear normal. And there was nothing more normal than working a shitty corporate gig to slowly climb the career ladder.

Letting out a long groan, Tori smoothed her suit on reflex and dropped into one of the two chairs in front of Ivan's desk. With a quick motion, she pulled out her phone to go over the day's schedule. “Okay, it looks like I've got a small gap between your post-lunch presentation review and the meeting's actual start. Maybe I'll swing by Ridge City Grinders and grab some espresso. It won't turn me into rainbows and sunshine, but I should be able to smile my way through most of the afternoon.”

“You're thinking too small,” Ivan told her. Finally glancing up from his desk, he reached into a nearby drawer and pulled out his company credit card. “Call Chloe and have her set up an order for the group ahead of time. That way, you can walk in with a nice treat to get everyone over the post-lunch slump. Remember: taking the initiative earns you big points with the higher-ups.”

Reaching slightly, Tori accepted the card and tucked it away in her pocket. “I already took bullets for the company. Now they want me to take

initiative, too?”

“That was last quarter. You’re only as good as your most recent accomplishments.”

Ivan turned back to the task at hand, and Tori didn’t object. She was one of the few people who knew how much work he needed to get done before their meeting kicked off. Instead, she headed out to drop off more documents with one of the other managers.

It was a little galling at times, when she really thought about the fact that Vendallia was a subsidiary of Indigo Technologies, the company that Wade Wyatt owned. They were trying to impress people who were supposedly higher on the food chain than them, when, in reality, she and Ivan had both shared beers with the man sitting at the tiptop of the ladder. If anything, other people should be kissing up to them. But that was the trouble with secret identities: you couldn’t use the relationships your costumed self might have without raising questions. Tori Rivas was a low-level, white-collar worker, only recently promoted from intern.

If she wanted to climb higher, she’d have to do it with solid work and afternoon coffee.



“—and it looks like public perception of the AHC has gone up measurably after last night’s spectacle. We’ll have to wait to see if this is a temporary bump or a long-term gain; however, overall we do seem to be regaining people’s trust after the Apollo incident.”

Quorum set the report down and looked at the other two people in the room. Professor Quantum seemed bored, which was neither a surprise nor a slight. He always appeared to be some level of disinterested—when there were no cameras around, at least. For a man with his intellect, meetings like this probably felt like time-wasting torture, and yet he still came. They’d all seen what happened when the Champions’ Congress drifted apart, and it was a mess they were working daily to clean up.

Lodestar, on the other hand, appeared engaged. While she was in costume, her power wasn’t currently activated, meaning she had chestnut-colored hair and lacked the signature glow that often surrounded her. It made her less distracting, which Quorum appreciated during these private

meetings. She was flipping through the handouts Quorum had made, looking over the figures their PR department had brought around to them this morning.

“We’re still a long way from where we were in the public’s eye,” Lodestar noted.

“One of the AHC’s leaders was put on public trial for colluding with a villain, planting evidence, and partially causing a city-wide brawl. Add in that it came to light we’ve been secretly letting criminals out of jail and I’m amazed we’ve made such strides of recovery at all.”

Lodestar didn’t bother to correct Professor Quantum about the fact that, legally, that part wasn’t on the AHC. Mostly because it didn’t matter. Technically, the government had created the Orion protocol, a caveat in the law that allowed convicted villains their freedom if they assisted in stopping potentially world-ending threats, but the government wasn’t the face of keeping meta-human peace. That honor and burden had been thrust upon the Alliance of Heroic Champions, and they were the ones at the center of the scandal when the truth came out.

“On that note, I have an order of business to raise.” Professor Quantum stood as he spoke, a habit from the older days when there had been more spectacle and protocol to these meetings. Despite being the oldest meta-human in the room (in fact, Professor Quantum was the first known meta-human at all, as *his* experiment had allowed new elements into the world, altering the laws of science as they’d then been understood), he never looked older than a man in his early forties. Twin streaks of gray ran along the otherwise dark hair at his temples, and his glowing blue eyes were hidden behind a pair of spectacles that did far more than correct poor vision, which he didn’t have. As always, he wore the same outfit: a dark, tailored suit under a crisp white lab coat that floated out behind him.

“As you both know, earlier this week, my latest experiments arrived in Ridge City. Since we had the impending spaceship to deal with, I tabled the issue; however, now that the threat has passed, I’d like to discuss how we are going to manage their debut.”

“We’re not.” Lodestar’s reply was brisk and automatic. She set her shoulders, ready for Professor Quantum to fight her on the issue and unwilling to give ground. “We’ve already talked about this. No more debuts. No more managing every angle of a superhero’s career and cherry-picking the ones who get media attention. Everyone does the best job they

can because it's the right way to use our gifts. The people will love who they choose to love, and the rest will go to bed every night with the consolation prize of knowing they made the world a safer place."

"That's all well and good for some two-bit street urchin who gains the ability to chat with frogs or what have you, but you must realize we're talking about the continuation of a legacy. I have spent years developing this team to be the perfect combination of assets, appeal, and abilities. You want me to just turn them loose in the streets without so much as even a press conference?" Professor Quantum was staring right back at her, which was no small feat. Lodestar might be the public face of the AHC, and doubtlessly one of the strongest meta-humans on Earth, but Professor Quantum wasn't far behind her. He'd kept the peace and run his own superhero organization for decades before she came onto the scene.

"We didn't have any sort of media push when we started, and all of us managed fine. If your next generation can't do the same, are they really an improvement?" Lodestar was going after his pride, a tactic Quorum had seen her use many times in the past. It didn't always work, but Professor Quantum's ego was too large a target to miss completely.

"The world lacked constant media saturation when I began my work, and things were different even when you started. The internet was barely blooming, people weren't under a constant barrage of information coming out of their handheld devices, televisions, and screens at every..." Professor Quantum trailed off, realizing he'd slipped off into a tangent. "Very well, Lodestar. Perhaps you're right. Showing them special treatment could have a negative effect, make them seem pampered rather than deserving of their accolades. Does the Champions' Congress have any objection to me turning them loose as soon as possible? If they are to be judged by their deeds, then I would like to permit them to begin work. Today. Within the hour, if possible."

Lodestar threw a brief glance at Quorum, then nodded. "I don't see any issue with that. Granted, they haven't been formally vetted yet, but I've seen the footage from your island and shaken their hands. All four seem competent."

It was an olive branch, a compromise. Rather than making them jump through hoops or formality like any other new cape would, Lodestar was permitting the team to head out into the field. So far as Quorum could tell, it seemed a fair halfway point, so he nodded his head as well.

But it didn't escape his notice that Professor Quantum looked a bit smug as he retook his seat seconds later. While Quorum couldn't be entirely sure, he was almost certain this was the outcome Professor Quantum had been aiming for all along.



Tori was five steps out of Ridge City Grinders, her arms weighed down by the enormous plastic bag full of carefully packed to-go cups, as well as her own entire eight-ounce cup of espresso, when the explosion rocked the street. It was only thanks to her training that she stayed physical, resisting the reflexive urge to turn into living fire. While all her clothing was made out of a special material that would shift with her, that wouldn't do much to protect the coffee, and it certainly wouldn't save her secret from the dozens of panicking witnesses yelling and running through the street. Officially speaking, Tori Rivas was a perfectly mundane and normal human being. Hephaestus was the only one with powers, and not even the capes knew what lurked beneath the suit's metallic exterior.

As she backpedaled toward the sidewalk, her eyes scanned about, rapidly assessing the situation. Smoke was pouring out from a wall in one of the nearby buildings. If memory served, that place was a jewelry store. What kind of damn idiots were robbing a jewelry store in broad daylight in the same section of town where the Alliance of Heroic fucking Champions had their national headquarters? Tori shook her head, thankful yet again for the guild that had taken her in and shown her the proper way villains were meant to conduct themselves. This was the sort of thing that would get someone expelled from their organization in a very permanent fashion. Breaking the guild's code was a zero-tolerance sin, one that came with punishment carried out by people on the same level as Ivan.

From the smoke, Tori saw five figures emerge, each clad in all black, wearing ski masks and carting large duffel bags. One person, much taller than the other four, was strapped down with at least a dozen bags: meta-human with augmented strength, obviously. Already Tori could hear the sirens of the police making their approach, but with a brute in the mix, these crooks would be more than the brass could handle.



While Tori had admittedly not always been the most dutiful or attentive apprentice, some of Ivan's teachings had sunk in better than others. One of the most important lessons seemed quite relevant at the moment: if there were going to be capes in your vicinity, be somewhere else.

Lugging her bag of coffee—she would be *damned* if she was going to fill out the forms needed to use a company credit card and then lose the goods—Tori tried to head further up the sidewalk, back toward the office. It was tough at first, since she had to fight a terrified crowd, but they thinned out quickly. Most were hurrying inside nearby buildings, failing to realize that the structures they were trusting to keep them safe could easily be brought down on their heads by the wrong sort of meta. At least out in the open Tori had space to move.

She'd only gotten twenty feet away before the first cop car arrived; poor bastards must have been on patrol nearby. From the other end of the street came what looked like a retrofitted minibus, armored and strapped down with guns. As the crooks began loading their wares into the bus, the big guy dashed over to the police car. Tori's breath caught in her throat. Escape was one thing; doing nothing while innocent people got killed was a whole other issue. Where the hell were the capes, anyway? This was their town, and they could sure as shit use the publicity.

Thankfully, the police were clearly veterans of living in Ridge City. As the hulking criminal wrapped his hands around the top of their patrol car and lifted it overhead, both officers popped the doors and leapt out, rolling to safety and coming up with their weapons drawn. One squeezed off a shot that hit their attacker in the left leg, tearing a hole in his pants but otherwise doing no damage.

What it did manage to do, however, was draw the brute's attention. Even through the ski mask and at her distance, Tori could see the disdain in the meta-human's eyes as he glared at the cop who'd shot him. Without so much as a glance over his shoulder, the muscular beast of a man tossed the police car behind him like an unrepentant litterbug throwing away a burger wrapper.

Though the shot might have been unaimed, it still had plenty of power. The car soared through the air, away from the bus with the other criminals, clearing the small crowd of civilians and tumbling down on a direct course for the ground.

Unfortunately, the spot of street it was hurtling toward was exactly where Tori was currently standing.

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## Chapter 2

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The blast of wind was her only warning before Tori found herself suddenly hurtling through the air, cradled in a pair of lean, strong arms. A horrific cacophony of smashing metal and shattering concrete barely reached her ears over the sound of the wind, the car crumpling down in the spot where Tori had been standing. It was so close, she could still see her bag of coffees only a few feet away; apparently, it had slipped from her hand in the rescue.

While the impact wouldn't have killed her—her fire form had an abundance of uses, and this occasion fit well within her wheelhouse—her savior had no way of knowing that. And, in truth, this did save her the complication of publicly using her powers. Just as Tori tried to twist and get a better look at her rescuer, the wind came to a sudden, unexpected halt.

The result of this unfortunate timing was that Tori found herself gazing upward at her helper right as they came to a stop in front of a small crowd of onlookers, most of whom had produced camera phones. To anyone viewing this from the outside, it no doubt appeared as though she was enraptured by this man, rather than trying to figure out what sort of facial features rested below the bright blue mask covering everything except his nostrils, eyes, and mouth. The mask clung so tight, it could almost have been mistaken for paint; there was no gap between the face and the covering.

“Sorry for the abrupt pickup, but I thought you'd prefer it to a total crash-and-burn.”

Not the smoothest line she'd ever heard, but for a cape new on the scene, it was decent. Actually, now that she was really looking, Tori

realized that this fellow appeared *much* too put together for a cape she'd never seen before.

He was of average height, lean and muscular—no surprise, given that he'd just shown off super-speed. Brown hair and eyes were the only features the mask gave away, and the rest of his costume was strikingly similar to the facial accessory: blue material, thicker in some places than in others, along with a telltale notch or switch that betrayed functionality. There was also a thick bracer on one wrist—most likely control terminals for whatever hidden systems were at work. This cape wasn't just rocking a costume: he had an outfit, something made specifically to help him fight crime. A stylized "T" was on his left pectoral, and Tori couldn't help but feel like she'd seen all of this before. Not quite the same, but unmistakably similar.

"Oh no!" In front of Tori, a man's eyes went wide as he looked back at the scene of the crime. She whipped her head around, jaw nearly dropping in surprise. One of the goons had lifted an automatic weapon and was starting to angle it toward the onlookers.

Holy *shit*. Were these people insane? Spraying down citizens might cause enough panic to cloak an escape, but the AHC would never stand for that kind of display of violence. And that was assuming they ever got the chance to lay a finger on these idiots. If anyone from the guild learned about this, they'd soak the earth in these idiots' blood, then give them transfusions to make it last longer. This was Ridge City; even villains had friends and family here.

Thankfully, as visions of the worst flickered through Tori's mind, the gun vanished from its owner's hands. Seconds later, the weapon crashed heavily to the ground, shattering on impact.

"Ma'am, I need to set you down now. There's still work to do."

Well, *that* was embarrassing. True to form, Tori had gotten so lost in her curiosity that she'd forgotten her surroundings, including the fact that she was still hanging on to the super-speed guy who'd helped her out. In the rush of speed, clinging to him had seemed natural, though now she realized it likely appeared quite different to the onlookers.

With as much dignity as she could muster, Tori freed herself from the blue-clad mystery cape, who vanished in a blur. He reappeared over by the criminals, where Tori could now see three figures wearing what seemed to be matching outfits standing just outside of proper view. Either this was the

fashion-coincidence of a lifetime, or they had an entire team of capes here to help out. Despite their technically being on opposite sides, Tori was happy to see them. This was the sort of chaotic mess that neither organization approved of.

“Hey there, folks. Have no fear about the voice coming out of your phones and nearby speakers. Just one of my many tricks, and the reason they call me Presto. No, not the fast one who just saved that lady. His name is Tachyonic, master of speed and time. Watch him go—isn’t he something?”

True to the voice’s promise, Tachyonic zipped around one of the would-be robbers, easily knocking him over. With that kind of speed, everyone except the strong-meta should be already captured. This wasn’t just about foiling a crime, then. Someone was throwing themselves a debut.

From the decked-out minibus, the sound of machinery engaging could be heard. Evidently, these robbers had come expecting resistance. It was significantly *less* likely they had been prepared for the beam of energy that carved neatly through the entire bus, cutting the section with the engine off from the rest of the vehicle entirely. Out of this divide stepped a woman whose costume matched Tachyonic’s, though Tori noted that this one had a noticeably more revealing cut, emphasized all the more by the woman’s figure.

“That bombshell is Plasmodia. Keep your distance, fellas. Anything that hot is bound to burn, and if her looks don’t do it, then her power to conjure, shape, and direct raw plasma energy absolutely will.”

The voice was starting to wear on her nerves. If escape had been at all possible, Tori would have been running for it. Unfortunately, between the fight to her fore and the giant crowd to her rear, there was no easily slipping away. Especially after being saved by Tachyonic. She could *feel* the stares and whispers, which only made it worse. Moving would trigger their attention. Her best shot was to wait until the capes won, then make a break for it in the ensuing celebration.

Big-meta wasn’t too keen on seeing the bus get destroyed, it turned out. He slammed a mighty boot into the street and blasted forward, plainly intending to lay out Plasmodia. Rookie mistake, at a glance. After she’d sliced through reinforced metal with ease, this idiot should assume she could cut him, too. He’d know that, if he’d gotten proper guild training, just like he’d know to never make a big move in a situation like this.

The whole thing was a play. These capes were way too strong for this level of incident; they had the entire thing in total control. Which meant the only reason no one had touched the big, obviously-criminal meta was that they were leaving it for some remaining unnamed member of the team.

Sure enough, as the lumbering crook drew close, another person in a blue costume struck. This one was blond, taller and more muscular than Tachyonic by a wide margin, though not quite so huge that he gave himself away as a meta. From a size perspective, the criminal meta had the advantage. That was one more important lesson taught by the guild, however: size meant little in the world of super-human abilities.

With unexpected grace, the new cape caught his opponent mid-charge, executed a perfect flip, driving him into the ground, and then punched. Once. That was all it took to make the hulking crook go limp. Not a small feat, given the strength that robber had demonstrated. Whoever the new guy was, he definitely had power to spare.

“And that, my wonderful audience, is our leader. The inheritor to history’s greatest superhero, the man who will usher in a new age of peace and justice. I give you, the one, the only... Agent Quantum!”

For the most part, the crowd had rolled with this incident pretty well. Outside of the moments when they’d felt directly threatened, the scene was more interesting than scary once the capes arrived. To many Ridge City citizens, this was old hat; it happened every time a new bunch of metas popped up. At that announcement, however, the entire crowd went silent in shock. Just in time, as it turned out, because the voice on their speakers was rising.

“That is right, folks. You are the fortunate few who can look back upon your life and say that you—yes, you—were there the day the New Science Sentries appeared to save the world. All right, team, time for the Big Finish!”

A final form clad in blue appeared, as if from nowhere. This one was covered head-to-toe in the material, not so much as an eyehole breaking the surface. Presto had appeared at last, and with a wave of his hands, the blue form made two of the criminals vanish. They reappeared fifty feet up, screaming as they dropped before disappearing five feet from the ground, only to once more pop out fifty feet up. Tachyonic zipped around, tying up all the remaining bodies, while Plasmodia yanked out the minibus driver and tossed him over for Tachyonic to wrap up. Once Agent Quantum was

sure the big meta was down and bound, he leapt up, snaring both crooks falling from the sky in a single arm before settling them carefully down as they begged to be cuffed. If neither man started the day with a fear of heights, they would certainly have one now.

“Thank you, citizens of Ridge City!” Presto’s voice echoed from the speakers, nearly beaten out by people’s cheering. As they yelled, Tori felt the crowd loosen. She quietly moved toward the sidewalk, putting as much distance as possible between herself and the onlookers. She wasn’t quite quick enough to escape the rest of Presto’s spiel, though.

“We are the New Science Sentries, Ridge City’s freshest, greatest team of superheroes. Be sure to tag us when you post pics and video of this!”

Thanks to years of learning to pass unnoticed, and perhaps a little guild training here and there, Tori managed to duck through several boutiques and small businesses, eventually making her way back to the Vendallia Industries offices. She was late, for sure, but had one hell of an excuse if Ivan tried to give her crap. At least she’d been smart about it. No revealing of powers. No getting involved with crooks or capes. Except for the getting saved part, she’d been a model bystander. While that bit was not-so-great, she couldn’t think of a better move to have made. The pictures would be a short-lived embarrassment until another cape did some remarkable feat—probably Lodestar knocking out a kraken, or the like.

Tori was so absorbed in the fallout from her encounter that she didn’t realize it hadn’t ended quite yet. As she passed an alley, a form leapt out. Thanks to the flash of blue, she caught on in time and didn’t roast him, but it was closer than it should have been.

“Miss, I think you dropped this.” Tachyonic had appeared, holding her sack of what had to be spilled coffee. Of course he had. This was what capes did, especially when they were coordinating a debut.

“Thanks.” Tori looked in the bag, noting that for the most part, the contents had held together just fine. God bless Chloe and her love for extra-durable packing. As she rifled through the bag, however, Tori realized there was indeed one thing missing. In the chaos of escape, she hadn’t yet thought to miss it, but now, there was nothing she wanted more. “Wait, where’s the receipt?”

That earned her a look of surprise. That’s how she interpreted the widening eyes, anyway. “Do you think I shortchanged you on the contents?”

“I don’t know, was that part of the show?” It wasn’t fair, not really—she could tell the team hadn’t caused the incident, they’d just made use of it—but that didn’t lessen the tightening in her stomach as she hunted for the receipt.

“What... do you mean?” The unshakeable surety of Tachyonic was starting to slip, a keen awareness slipping into his eyes.

Setting down the bag, Tori kneeled on the sidewalk and dug in earnest, delving into the section of the bag where spills had occurred. “Come on. You had a team member hack the nearby speakers to emcee the whole thing. Do you seriously not realize we can tell you were toying with those goons? They had backing and muscle and equally no idea what to do with it. The whole fight should have been over in seconds, but that doesn’t make for as viral of a spectacle, right? I don’t know how Donald puts up with you image-obsessed assholes.”

Her tirade had taken Tachyonic back a few mental steps. As it wound down, he appeared to find himself and dig in, going so far as to actually cross his arms. “Most people would be thankful to have gotten saved.”

“Yeah? Welcome to Ridge City, where we hold our capes to higher standards. They save people first, show off second. If you can’t live up to that, then this city isn’t for you. Take your ass to Tampa. I hear they’ve got a solid rookie program.” With great effort, Tori pulled herself up from the ground. The receipt wasn’t in there. It was gone. “Maybe out there, they can teach you that if you save someone in the public eye, especially during your debut, it’s not a great idea to leave behind the documentation that gives away my first name and employer.”

She was a little surprised, but he seemed to get the implication at once. Part of her had been preparing to walk him through the issue.

“Ah. Someone out there has a picture of me saving you, along with at least your first name and who you work for. Pair that with my team making our debut today, while taking on the legacy of the greatest superhero team in history, and it makes for an easy human-interest angle. I don’t suppose there was any chance you’re one of those people who is secretly hoping for a lot of fame and attention from strangers?”

“Basically the exact opposite,” Tori replied.

“I’ll... see what I can do.” Tachyonic vanished without another word—a wise decision in Tori’s estimation. His empty promise was just that: empty.



There was no power in existence that could tamp down on humanity's love of gossip or interest in capes.

Whether she liked or not—and she very much did *not*—Tori Rivas was about to get her fifteen minutes of fame.

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## Chapter 3

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Working in downtown Ridge City meant that occasionally, an emergency broadcast went off, letting everyone know that there was some sort of meta-event happening and they should all stay indoors. Ivan felt minimal concern when one activated shortly after Tori left. The odds of it being near her were slim, and she was a villain of the guild. She could handle being around some action.

Still, his worry did arise when a call on his cell phone lit up. It was rare for people to reach out directly like this. Superiors preferred email, the guild had its own channels, and Wade managed to keep all guild members off telemarketing and robocall lists—though that was more for the marketers’ safety than anything else. As his eyes fell upon the name, Ivan’s worry was dispelled, replaced by the constant rock of terror he carried with him at all times. Janet was calling, which meant something was going on with their kids. It was the only topic they actively communicated over.

Snatching it up, Ivan immediately accepted the call. “Janet, always a pleasure. Is everything okay?”

“Rick hasn’t suddenly developed powers, too, if that’s what you mean.” Ivan winced at that. Technically, they didn’t know how Beth had been turned into a meta-human, though they shared the same suspicion that it was connected to Ivan’s past in some way. “But we do have a problem. Beth’s Starscout cluster is due to start having meetings again soon, and they keep kicking back her registration. There’s a new cluster leader taking over for Dr. Randall. I’m not sure if the replacement is trying to lower his headcount by shuffling Beth out, or if he’s just terrible at paperwork. Either

way, we need to handle it. I've got to do a guest lecture tonight, and Juan is taking Rick to his mathematics club. Can you go straighten this out?"

On the surface, it was a perfectly normal request for a wife to make of her ex-husband. The issue here was that Janet rarely reached out, and it was even less common for her to ask for a favor. While she'd accepted his presence in their children's lives, it didn't mean she went out of her way to make it easier. Some might have mistaken her attitude for spite, but Ivan knew better. Janet's focus was entirely on the safety of their kids. Having a famous villain as a father would make things endlessly more complicated for them, so she tried to put distance between that legacy and the innocent offspring who had nothing to do with Fornax.

All of which meant that if Janet was asking him to step in, there was a reason. "Any suspicion of what the issue might be? If I know the problem, it'll make finding a solution easier."

"I have a hunch. I think you should draw your own conclusions, though. Just make sure you take care of it. Beth's been in the same cluster since she started as a Sparkscout, with the same friends. Between her school falling down and turning into a meta-human, she needs some stability. Please don't let her down."

The please was unnecessary, as was anything beyond the request itself. Ivan knew quite well how much turmoil his daughter had seen. She would *not* lose this, too.

"I'll handle it after work. My evening is quite free."

No sooner had the words left his mouth than Tori burst into his office, looking quite a bit rougher than she had upon leaving and without any coffee in hand.

"Janet, I need to let you go. Looks like another situation has just come up."



Donald stood in the gym next to Ren, watching the silent, wall-mounted television along with the myriad of other sweating forms. When he'd become a superhero and joined the Alliance of Heroic Champions, part of him had thought moments like this were long past—seeing some new cape swing into action on a screen, being caught completely unaware by the

sudden emergence of an incredible new force for good. Amazingly, though he'd racked up a few fights of his own now, he still felt that same sense of wonder he'd had while watching capes as a kid. If Donald was the only one feeling that way at first, he damn sure wasn't once *that* name was flashed across the screen.

"What!?"

It was impossible to say which of the many screeching voices owned that particular verbal expulsion, nor did it matter. The words easily summarized the general feeling in the AHC's gym.

The Science Sentries were the original, as in *original*-original, superhero team. Formed a few years after Professor Quantum's experiment tweaked the laws of physics, introducing entire new meta-elements and strange magical forces, the Science Sentries were in many ways a precursor to the League of Metas, which organized capes before the Alliance of Heroic Champions was formed. But they'd been disbanded since the mid-seventies, as everyone save Professor Quantum had either died or grown too old to keep doing the work. And now, decades later, he was just handing over the title to some new team?

No... that wasn't right. Donald kept watching the screen as the shaky cell-phone-camera footage jumped around. The news report was doing a hack job editing it all together; they'd jumped right in during the middle of the fray. Nevertheless, this team, whoever they were, had visible skill to burn. They were nothing like he and Ren had been in their first battle, even if that had admittedly been against an inter-dimensional monster. These four were coordinated, practiced, calm. If this really was their first official outing, then they must have trained for years prior to do it like this. That would make a lot more sense; Professor Quantum was a man who took care of his legacy. Handing over the name "Science Sentries" wasn't something he'd do easily.

"The competition just got tougher." Ren kept watching the screen—which usually showed exercise forms or cooking-contest shows, depending on who got to the remote first—but his arms picked up a pair of extremely heavy weights as he began to do curls. Seconds later, his tail snaked around a third weight and began to lift as well, though this one was notably lighter.

"They're our allies, not our competition," Donald pointed out.

Ren made an inhuman noise in his throat, the intended implication entirely lost on Donald. Being friends with someone who was mostly

animal took practice, especially in the realm of non-verbal communication, but they'd made steady progress since first teaming up. "Do you see any inherent issue with trying to be the best superhero you can possibly be?"

"Of course not."

"Then you should accept that as much as these people are our friends and allies, they're also our competition. We all want to be the best. Me, you, Bloopston over there by the water fountain, Big Swing on the deadlift—even the established capes like Battle Cry and Dapper Doll are looking higher up the mountain to the Champions' Congress." Ren kept on lifting as he spoke, and Donald noticed his words seemed to be inspiring several of the others as well. Even he felt his fingers itch for a controller; playing games was the way Donald improved his digital inventory.

Had the screen not changed, Donald might have been tempted to point out the flaw in Ren's philosophy: none of them would ever be the best. As a team, that title could be claimed. However, on an individual front, the battle was lost before it started. There was only one person who was the strongest, the toughest, the surest. When everything and everyone else failed, Lodestar came through.

Donald had witnessed her in person only twice. Once in childhood, and once when they were breaking into the AHC headquarters to free Quorum. Both times were seared into his memory. Lodestar was the kind of person who left an impression.

However, before any of that could escape his lips, a new clip of footage popped up on the screen. This time, rather than focus on the fight, it was a clip of the one called Tachyonic saving a civilian from certain death. Donald almost couldn't believe his eyes as the scene played out, showing Tachyonic stop after a sudden surge of movement, carefully holding a very recognizable woman in his arms.

It was a painfully familiar image to Donald—one from his most private fantasies, where he held Tachyonic's position, finally showing his crush the kind of capable superhero he'd become. Seeing that she'd been in danger was bad enough; watching that unexpectedly soft gaze upon Tachyonic's face... Donald found himself markedly less excited about this new team than he had been seconds ago.

Setting down a weight, Ren pointed a claw up toward the screen. "Hey, isn't that Tori?"

“I’m not sure. The picture from the camera is a little blurry. Could be somebody else.” Donald wasn’t even sure why he bothered with the lie, other than to have a few extra moments to process the sudden surprise.

Ren called across the gym to a scaly woman with visible gills and webbed fingers. “Hey, Bloopston, give us sound!”

Bloopston picked up a nearby remote from the water cooler and cranked the volume as requested.

“—reports are coming in from the Alliance of Heroic Champions that these are indeed inheritors to the Science Sentries mantle, not pretenders with a false claim as we’ve seen before. Additionally, they would request that the civilians and police involved in the incident be left unbothered. While the woman in this video’s name has been leaked online thanks to some active sleuths on the scene, we will of course not be repeating it here, and would like to encourage our viewers to please respect the AHC’s plea for discretion.”

As the anchor spoke, the runner on the bottom of the screen showing the broadcast’s social media feed began to light up with posts, people spamming Tori’s name over and over, proving once more that humanity was definitely not prepared for the level of technology it had access to. The reporter continued, oblivious to the fact he was being undermined as he launched into a history lesson on the original Science Sentries.

Donald paused only long enough to give Ren a quick glance before darting out on a direct course for his phone. This time, there was no issue in the communication, as Ren got immediately out of the way. When it mattered, they understood each other just fine, and this *definitely* mattered.



One day. One damn day, and Vernon’s new team was already causing her trouble.

Helen sat at home, Penelope at her summer day camp, watching the video on replay. She’d already done a few soundbites for the media and made a quick call to Quorum, but that was all just to handle this new team’s arrival on the scene. The bigger problem was that Tachyonic had gone and kicked a hornet’s nest. Except hornets would be infinitely better than what lurked inside Tori’s hive.

Her core dilemma was one of morality and information. A key aspect of the AHC was that it did *not* exist entirely outside the law; that was a League of Metas philosophy that was stomped out when the organization died. Yes, capes were empowered to take extraordinary actions, especially in dire circumstances, but they were not judges and juries themselves. Criminals, meta or human, went through the legal system; at least, the ones who let themselves be taken in. Technically speaking, there was no warrant out for Tori Rivas. She was an innocent civilian, so far as the law was concerned.

Hephaestus, on the other hand, was wanted in connection to a museum heist. The metal-suited crook was on the scene and had dealt with members of the AHC in the escape. The conundrum was that there was no evidence in Helen's possession that linked these two identities together. Quorum would put it together, and Vernon might, if he cared enough to realize she was Ivan's "niece" in documentation. As for the new team, there was essentially zero chance they'd realized they'd just put a potential supervillain on national television and framed her as a helpless damsel in distress.

After a few decades of this job, it was hard not to see the patterns. Peaks and valleys, the changing of the ages. Some parts held constant, though. Bank robbers always threw the gun when the bullets ran out, incompetent crooks had a strange knack for getting their hands on dynamite, and the media loved an image that told an instant story. A freeze-frame of a new superhero holding what appeared to be an adoring woman he'd just saved fit the mold perfectly. That photo of Tori and Tachyonic was going to play. Given that her name was already out there, that meant attention.

First things first: she needed to get a protective detail around Tori. With the guild no longer capable of patrolling the underworld, things were changing. The old rules were starting to be ignored as up-and-comers decided to test their limits. So far, the AHC had been holding strong, but crime was increasing all over the globe. Helen couldn't assume that no one would try to take a run at Tori, just for the sin of being vaguely connected to a cape. People had tried more over less.

It wasn't that she was worried for Tori—that guild didn't admit members who couldn't handle themselves. No, Helen's worry was for what Tori or—gods forbid—Ivan would do to anyone that tried to move against her. While they might no longer be ruling over crime thanks to Apollo shoving them into the light, the guild did have an extremely clear process

on what happened to those who attacked their members directly. Worse, they knew how to do it without leaving evidence behind.

As she picked up the phone, Helen decided her next call was going to be to Vernon, or rather, Professor Quantum, since this would be an official communication. They needed to have a talk about that team of his. Letting them skip ahead to fieldwork hadn't been entirely off base, not with the power they were displaying, but if these four were going to be in the AHC, then they needed to learn to do the job properly.



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## Chapter 4

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There weren't many excuses one could offer up for missing a meeting with management, but being drawn into an attempted robbery's chaos was a hard one to argue with. Especially when there was documentation of the incident all over the news. Tori was formally excused from work for the remainder of the day; they even released Ivan, as well, since he was ostensibly her only local family. How much of that was management being kind and how much was Ivan using his unknown connections, Tori genuinely had no idea.

Rather than go to her own apartment, they instead headed straight to Ivan's townhouse. "By now, reporters have your address," Ivan explained as Tori tried to settle on the couch. This new place was slick, with high-end appliances and fancy furniture, but it lacked the authentic comfort of Ivan's real house. Sadly, that had played host to a meta-human brawl between Hephaestus and a traitor of the guild, which had left it in an... uninhabitable state. Until the repairs were completed, Ivan was stuck in this swanky place, not that he seemed to care. The only requests Tori saw him make when these arrangements were being set up were for a modern kitchen and rooms for both of his kids. Ivan had his priorities.

"Couldn't I turn the hose on them or something? It can't be legal to hang out in front of my building, hoping to harass me." Tori had been looking forward to a quiet evening of refining her meta-suit for the guild's reopening that weekend. Now she was wondering if she'd have to build some sort of hidden tunnel system just to attend. Actually, now that she considered it, some secret entrances and escape hatches were a good idea in general.

“The countless thespians, models, and other famous folk in your shoes have tried such methods, few of which were successful. While our media cycle has kicked up several notches, you’re not the first person to get a shot of fame for being saved by a cape. Some try to turn it into careers of their own. Most fade away after a new story pops up. My advice is to lay low and wait it out. After a day or two, you can probably go home safely. Until then, feel free to use Beth’s room.”

Despite how unfunny the situation was, Tori still let out a short chuckle. “So, this was all just an elaborate plan to get me to be your housemate again. I respect the effort, but if you’re lonely, maybe move in with Wade? He’s one of the few people you like.”

Ivan shuddered, albeit slightly, at the suggestion. “Impossible. We’ve already lived together, and the man is an abhorrent slob when at home—and do keep in mind that critique is coming from someone who’s raising a teenager. The original reason he invented robots that do tasks like cleaning or driving was to appease me after a particularly strong argument over when a trash can needs to be emptied.”

For a moment, Tori tried to picture it. Two of the worlds’ most powerful villains, in their primes, having a heated discussion about who was dragging ass on their chores. Hard as she worked, the image of Fornax and Doctor Mechaniacal bickering about trash refused to form. Ivan and Wade, however, she conjured with minimal effort.

“Besides, how could I be lonely? Between you lot at the office, keeping an eye on the guild, and my actual children, it often feels like I go entire weeks without spare moments to rub together.” Ivan’s eyes darted to the watch on his wrist. “On that note, I’m afraid I have an errand to run. My sincere apologies, but I made the commitment before I was aware of your situation. Please get comfortable. I can grab us some fast food on the way back.”

The room grew unexpectedly heavy as Tori narrowed her eyes. “Uh oh. What’s going on?”

“As I said, an errand I need to run. No need to pull out the suspicious stare.”

“Except you *never* do takeout when you can help it, and that goes double for fast food. You always stick to real meals, even when we get in late and doing something quick and greasy would be way easier. Sorry, Ivan, but you taught me that paying attention to details and listening to our

gut helps us stay alive. If I'm not high enough in the guild to know or whatever, fine, but say that. I don't need to be lied to."

Ivan both cursed and complimented his past self; the education provided to Tori had clearly been a comprehensive one. "The lie was for me, not you. Janet called and asked me to help with Beth's Starscout cluster. There's been an issue with her registration."

"I didn't know Beth was a Starscout," Tori said. "Hope they've improved the uniforms. Those old collars used to itch like all hell."

It was one of the few times she'd seen Ivan actually reel in surprise. "You were a Starscout?"

Her laughing smile faded, and Tori looked away. "Mom thought I needed socializing, said I was too preoccupied with research and experimentation. Started me as a Sparkscout, then graduated into Starscouts when I was old enough. I never liked any of the camping or outdoorsy stuff one bit, but I got to do it all with my mom, so now I can't help loving the memories."

"It's a good organization. Everything the founder hoped for." Ivan pressed on, hurrying past his slip-up before Tori could ask how he would possibly know a thing like that. "My fear is the fact that Janet felt the need to get me involved at all. She is not a woman to be taken lightly, especially where our children are concerned. If she wants me to deal with this, then the most likely reasons are because the situation requires a dangerously firm hand, or she somehow thinks the problem is my fault and expects me to solve it. I'm worried what that means for Beth and her group."

After a brief moment of consideration, Tori hopped up from the couch. She'd never gotten settled on it, anyway. "I'll come, too. Sitting around a strange place with nothing to work on is just going to make me stir-crazy, especially after today. Plus, I can be your Starscout expert, in case anyone tries to trick you with fake rules or policies."

It was a stretch, and they were both keenly aware of that. Ivan didn't blame Tori. Her entire world had gotten shaken up on a coffee-run mere hours ago; she needed time to process. And company, apparently. There was a small amount of merit in her proposal, though. Ivan had more than enough magic to tell when a human lied to him, but having her there to call out any bullshit was a more mundane option that demanded less explanation. For people in their position, appearing normal was among the highest of priorities.

“Just so we’re clear, Tori, this is a matter I take seriously.”

“I know how you feel about your kids, and Beth probably saved my life when her school collapsed. I’m not going to fuck around with something that girl cares about,” she replied.

“Good answer.” Ivan walked over to the table and grabbed his keys. “But keep your head down as we drive. Remember, for the moment, you’re a celebrity.”

Tori let out a groan that sounded like it had crawled all the way up from her toes. “I don’t suppose there’s any way I could convince you to let me ride in my Hephaestus helmet, is there?”



In the early days, though not quite as far back as her post-event, pre-Lodestar days, Helen had trouble controlling her power. It came bursting forth at the slightest desire, suffusing her body and lighting up everything in a three-block radius with her glow. Over time, and with significant practice, she’d learned to master her abilities, drawing only as much power as she wanted. It was that level of self-control that permitted Helen to last seven years without using the burning power that dwelled within her.

That same control was how she managed to illuminate only her hair and eyes at that moment, shifting into the appearance of Lodestar without calling up so much strength that she risked ripping a door from its hinges. Even in her most mundane form, Helen’s body was at peak human capacity for strength, agility, endurance, flexibility, and every other physical factor one could measure, so it wasn’t as if she felt defenseless. Besides, they were in the heart of the AHC, and she was about to walk into a room with four other superheroes.

Already waiting for her in the lounge were the New Science Sentries and a thin man with a receding hairline who was running around checking their vitals. One of Vernon’s—no, Professor Quantum’s—men. It was important to keep those lines in place when she was wearing her costume. Even if the world already knew who he was, it didn’t matter. Lodestar set the standard. If she got sloppy with official names, then others would think that was permissible—and it was *not*, even if she was annoyed with Professor Quantum for bringing a small staff along with his new team.

No matter how many times she had these sorts of meetings, she always took a deep breath for courage. Before grabbing the door handle, Helen drew in a single long gulp of air. Lodestar blew it out as she strolled into the room, smiling at the waiting team.

At the sight of her, Professor Quantum's lackey headed out the door as the rest of the room broke into a brief flurry of action.

The scramble wasn't new; she'd been famous for much too long. The team before her turned into a fray of limbs and movement as each and every one hopped to their feet. Only the shorter member, Presto, took his time rising. None were in masks, so she could see the excitement and terror shining out from each of their faces. It was hard to meet one's heroes; all the more so when they were *actual* superheroes. She'd stood where they were once and knew that feeling all too well, even so many years later.

"The New Science Sentries," Lodestar opened. "Those were some exceptional skills you showed off; I can see why Professor Quantum handed down the team name. But I'm getting ahead of myself. Let's start with introductions. I met you all briefly at the welcoming party, when you shook hands down the line, but I think we can do better than that. Agent Quantum, as leader, why don't you tell me about yourself and your team?"

Of them all, Presto looked the least nervous. That was, however, merely because he was a better actor than the others. Reading their body language, Agent Quantum appeared to be the one who actually *was* the least nervous, although it wasn't by a huge lead. He still stepped forward without fail, meeting her eyes as he spoke. Without the mask, it was clear he had the classic handsomeness so many capes prized: square jaw, bright eyes, and a smile that was commanding and friendly at the same time.

"Yes, ma'am. I'm Agent Quantum, but you can call me by my civilian name: Austin. Tachyonic and I were part of a prenatal setlium experiment prior to our births, which is where we both gained our abilities. Plasmodia and Presto were created through alternate means, and joined us on the island in late childhood. Our respective power sets are as follows: Tachyonic distorts the chronoflow around him to—"

"I'm up to speed on all your powers," Lodestar politely interrupted. "I was hoping to learn a little more about you as people. Let's start with an easy one, especially for recruits who have had their powers this long: what made you want to become superheroes?"

She considered this more of an icebreaker than a question. The answers people gave were usually off the cuff, either a quick pleasantry that had been practiced to death or the sort of sincere blathering that betrayed a lack of introspective thinking. The real reason was something one found out over time. Still, this was at least a conversational jump-off point that everyone who wanted to be a cape would be able to join in on.

“The chance to do great things.” Tachyonic was the one who spoke up, and he was lying, badly. So badly, in fact, that Lodestar suspected he didn’t expect or want this answer taken seriously. Interesting. She hadn’t known what to expect from that one, and so far still didn’t.

“I mean, let’s be honest here. I’m short, not much of a looker, and most people tend to find me... I think ‘abrasive’ is the word they use when they’re being nice. Guys like me have only one shot if we want to be rich, famous, and desired by lovely women all over the globe: superhero.” Presto vanished, reappearing on a nearby chair so he could look Lodestar more easily in the eyes. “Please feel free to call me Ike, by the way.”

Another liar, except this one *did* want to be believed. She shook his hand, absorbing the bluster to think over when she had more time.

As Lodestar turned away, she nearly bumped into Plasmodia, who had edged closer.

“I realize this sounds like I’m kissing up, but... the Day of Two Stars was what inspired me. I saw it from the ground, and even though I was a kid, I never forgot the way the sky lit up. I didn’t use my powers before then; I thought they were too dangerous. Watching you was when I realized that sometimes the world needs dangerous powers.”

“I haven’t heard anyone use that term in a while.” Lodestar noticed the flash of panic that ran through the young woman’s eyes and quickly spoke to reassure her. “I like it, mind you, it’s just one that fell out of fashion. Orion was a dangerous foe, and I wouldn’t face another like him if I had the choice. But knowing it helped show younger capes what we can do makes the fight worthwhile.”

Plasmodia nodded enthusiastically, a too-bright smile of capped teeth beaming on her face. “Oh! And I’m Eleanor, but everyone calls me Ellie! Sorry, should have opened with that.”

“It’s okay. There’s no set order to introductions.” Lodestar gave Plasmodia a quick wink before turning back to Agent Quantum. “And you, leader of the team? What got you into this field?”

“I was born for it. This is all I’ve ever known.” The reply was quick and crisp; he’d been ready for this. “With respect, that’s all I’d like to say for now, if that’s acceptable, ma’am. The rest is a personal matter.”

Lodestar closed her eyes for an extra-long blink. She didn’t just understand Austin’s reasoning; she’d expected it from at least one of them. Powers almost always came from chaos. It was the rare meta-human who gained their abilities in a peaceful, expected manner. And in that chaos, others often weren’t so lucky. It was a sad constant that so many meta-human powers were forged in tragedy, yet it was one she had to be aware of all the same.

“Perfectly fine. You certainly have the right to your own privacy,” Lodestar told him. “I’m not here today to pry as you get acclimated. I’m here to discuss your team, your performance today, and your future in the Alliance of Heroic Champions. My understanding is that Professor Quantum has been training all of you for years, both as individuals and as a team. Is that correct?”

All eyes darted to Austin a split second before he spoke. They were definitely cohesive as a unit, that much was clear. “Yes, ma’am. Our team composition wasn’t officially set until roughly two years ago, so we’ve only had that long to work together. Prior to that, we all received at least five years of personal development education.”

Once, before the AHC, before Lodestar, before the burning night that changed her life, Helen had been a young woman with dreams of acting. She’d even gotten in some training during her brief stint at college. That interest and talent had served her well many times through the years, and this was no exception. She successfully managed to keep the twist of incredulity from her expression. Two years of team training? Most were lucky to get two weeks before they were needed somewhere in the world. Professor Quantum had been polishing these four long past the point where it was worthwhile, just to make sure they’d do his legacy proud. Never mind that they’d have been better served doing the work and growing from experience: the image came first.

However, none of that was the team’s fault, which was why Lodestar denied the frustrated expression any time on her face. “That’s clear to see from watching the tapes. You’re all very gifted, and you work together extremely well.”

The foursome basked in the compliment like she'd breathed literal light into them. Even Presto's smile was glowing. It made the next line all the harder to speak, but she did so, anyway. Taking the tougher path was what being a cape was all about.

"Unfortunately, I think some of Professor Quantum's older, less-refined tactics might have slipped into your education. Today, for example. You all did an excellent job stopping the robbers, but it took at least four times as long as it should have with your skill levels. Any of them could have fired into the gathered civilians while you were taking turns putting on a show. Additionally, none of you were actually working crowd control. You are *extremely* lucky that your first job was in Ridge City, where the population knows what to do in a meta-fight. Another town, another country, people will try to get close for pictures and souvenirs. If things hadn't broken your way several times, the news would be reporting on the showboating new team who got civilians killed."

To an outside observer, it would appear like Lodestar had just slapped the New Science Sentries without so much as a twitch of her hand. Eyes wide, mouths agape, they definitely hadn't been prepared to get dressed down, and damn sure not by Lodestar herself. Years of practice giving these speeches had taught her not to pause here. It was best to power through while they were stunned into silence.

"That's the bad news. The good news is this: teaching you to be better superheroes is why the Alliance of Heroic Champions exists in the first place. We'll get you up to date on optimal meta-response strategies, run some drills for you to practice, and in no time, I have faith you'll be a team as useful and beloved as the original Science Sentries."

They didn't exactly look great, but at least most of their mouths had managed to close. Since they were taking it well, Lodestar opted to push ahead and knock out the last major item. Professor Quantum had kicked up a fuss at first, until she once again reminded him that they'd both started under similar conditions.

"One thing you need to learn about the AHC, though: we own our mistakes. Tachyonic, you brought a civilian in front of a crowd of cameras, posed with her, then let her name get leaked to the public. You put that woman in a position she didn't ask for, one that comes with actual danger. That means you're the one who is going to make it right."



As the New Science Sentries leaned in, Lodestar explained what their next few days would entail.

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## Chapter 5

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The laboratory was elegant: impeccably designed for both function and aesthetics, the work of someone who had spent untold years inside such research facilities. On a large screen, videos of the day's robbery played on a loop, cycling in new footage as soon as varying angles became available. Some were selected from public broadcasts; other bits were harvested from phones with poorly secured encryptions.

In the center of the lab, a gaunt man stood, watching the television. Average height, bland looks, and a slight stoop in his shoulders. The only parts of him that stood out were his perfectly bald head, unnervingly thin silhouette, and the shining intelligence in his eyes. Well, those features, and the small leak of dark smoke coming from his left wrist—but that could wait for the moment. His attention was rapt on the screen, and every time an anchor said the name of the new team, the man twitched as though it were a physical blow.

“About time you let them out. I was wondering how much more bait it would take. Those poor souls of yours have no idea who they're following. Someone should remedy that.” He glanced down, noticing the steady stream of smoke, and frowned. “I'll have to make myself presentable first, get a handle on my excitement. Can't give away the turn too soon.”

That bland face split into a wide-mouthed cackle, the man cracking up at his own pseudo-joke as he moved toward a massive machine taking up a full quarter of the laboratory. As the laughter rolled off him, so too did flecks of his skin, loosing more dark smoke into the air. With a single wave of his hand, the machine's door opened, and he vanished inside.



“Nice office.” Tori took note of the faux columns on the exterior: not especially good-looking, but visibly expensive. In a way, the columns were a snapshot of the entire office: designed by someone who wanted to exude the appearance of wealth, yet lacked any actual sense of taste or refinement. Granted, she wasn’t an especially swanky woman herself; Tori only developed a skill at gauging such factors because it mattered during her thief days. Knowing what a place was worth at a glance was part of using one’s time efficiently.

“Real estate developers are evidently doing well in the wake of Ridge City’s recent disaster.” Ivan somehow managed to keep the words neutral, despite the fact that the “disaster” he was referring to had kicked off when Ivan let himself slip back into Fornax and had chased Apollo around the city. While it was true that the incident, like the rest of the fiasco, was mostly Balaam’s fault, it didn’t mean the public at large had forgotten Fornax. Especially since he was supposed to have been dead.

The office was mostly empty, not surprising since the workday had ended. They heard conversation coming from a break area and saw a few bodies shuffling through the halls, so at least they weren’t meeting the guy in an empty building. That would have set off Tori’s trap instincts, though that might have been pretty entertaining in and of itself, she quickly realized. Anyone trying to jump Ivan from a dark alley was in for the surprise of their soon-to-be-ended lives.

Winding their way back through the carpeted halls, Ivan led her to a door labeled “Haywood Gibson” that had been left cracked open. They paused before Ivan touched the knob and gave Tori a pointed look, which she answered with a simple nod. From here on, it was Ivan’s show. She might not be his apprentice anymore, but she damn sure took a passenger position when it came to watching after Ivan’s children. Whatever happened would be up to him and no one else.

One quick knock was all Ivan gave before he shoved the door open to reveal a handsome man in a gray suit, working at his desk. The moment his eyes fell on Ivan, a rapid flash of emotions ran through him. Much as he tried to hide his real feelings under professional friendliness, there had been something dark for a split second. Anger, maybe, or perhaps fear? Whatever

it was, Tori knew Haywood wasn't happy to see them, regardless of the lies he was about to spit out.

"Mr. Gerhardt, glad you could make it, and right on time, at that." Haywood was up, extending a strong hand which Ivan shook. His frame and size betrayed the muscular definition beneath the suit, but if he was trying to intimidate Ivan with a squeeze, she doubted that Ivan would even notice. "Unfortunately, I'm afraid I don't have any better news to share. As I told your ex-wife, when Dr. Randall left Ridge City following that unpleasantness some weeks ago, the Starscouts had to be reorganized as personnel shifted to cover the gap. While I'm happy to be taking over for him as cluster leader, I don't have the power to change the fundamental makeup of the groups."

It was a fine story. Put the blame on bureaucracy, which was virtually impossible to disprove, and paint himself as a sympathetic ally. The trouble was... it was bullshit. Tori was able to tell that much, so Ivan definitely could. Still, just in case, she should do what she was ostensibly here for.

"Weird. Because my cluster leader left when I was five, and no one had to break up my group or transfer anyone out."

"I also find it fascinating that this 'reorganization' appears to have affected only one single child: my daughter." Ivan stared hard at Haywood for a long second, then did the last thing Tori was prepared for. He smiled. "But we're in luck. I happen to know some higher-ups in the Starscouts. If the issue is one of simple red tape, that should be an easy matter to cut through, with their cluster leader's permission."

Was he lying? It seemed possible, especially given who was at the *top* of the Starscouts, but Tori made it a policy not to rule out anything. She had friends on the cape-side; maybe there were some hidden strings Ivan could pull. Besides, what mattered wasn't whether it was true or not, only if Haywood believed them.

On that account, there was no need to worry. Whether it was Ivan's magic or years of experience speaking with authority as a manager, Haywood's blanched expression made it clear he'd bought the story. "I'd be happy to help in any way I can, but since meetings are due to start next week, I'm afraid there's probably not enough time to get it resolved. If she would like to transfer back in over Winter Break, I'm sure we can manage something."

“Don’t worry about that, Mr. Gibson. My contacts work fast. Beth will be back in her cluster before tomorrow evening. Unless there’s some other issue I haven’t been made aware of.” Ivan was still smiling, still polite, and Tori could feel her stomach tying itself in knots.

She’d seen Ivan on a murderous rampage as Fornax. She’d seen him be an efficient killer of the guild as Pseudonym. And she’d seen him manhandle Balaam as a vengeful father. She’d seen her teacher’s ire enough times that she’d begun to smell violence on the wind whenever someone near him walked a dangerous line. Tori took a few steps back, trying not to draw attention—not that she needed to worry. Both men’s eyes were locked on one another.

Haywood broke the stare, affecting an “aw-shucks” air as he switched tactics. “Okay, you got me. I didn’t want to bring this up, in light of you all knowing one another, but there’s been some concern from the other parents. Beth’s... condition makes her dangerous. She can produce sharp metal from her body on a whim, and that makes some parents nervous.”

“Then you tell them to eat shit, because the founding principle of Starscouts is that it’s for *everyone*. Any gender, any race, any species—meta, human, or in-between. Every child is welcome.” Tori was surprised at the ferocity in her voice. She wasn’t sure if the anger came from memories tied to her mother or the fact that of all the dumb stuff in the Starscouts, that part had always stuck with her.

“It’s fine, Tori. The problem isn’t with the parents. I know, because they are the parents of Beth’s friends. After her change, we reached out to each one—even sat down with a few—to make sure they understood what had happened. Not everyone was in love with it, but none of them would try to kick her out of her cluster. That would be Mr. Gibson’s decision.” Ivan never so much as glanced at Tori, his attention fully on the now slightly sweating real estate developer who was glaring right back.

In what had to be one of the all-time greatest pointless gestures, Haywood puffed his chest a bit, emphasizing the size difference between him and Ivan. She wished with all her heart that this idiot would swing, but that was likely hoping for too much.

“Fine, Mr. Gerhardt, you’ve worn me down. Yes, I am the one who transferred Beth out, and I’m not going to apologize for it. The rest of the kids in that cluster are nice, normal humans, and you want me to let some girl with a power she can barely control be in there with them? Forget it.

I'm putting my foot down as their leader. The safety of the cluster comes first."

For the first time, Ivan broke eye contact with Haywood, looking to Tori. "Is that excuse number three or four? I'm starting to lose count."

"One was a half-step between lies, so let's call it three, to be safe," Tori replied.

"I suspect this will be the last. False concern for others is often the bigot's final refuge, at least when patriotism is off the table." He turned back to Haywood, no longer smiling. "Now then, Mr. Gibson, your worry for the safety of children is admirable, which is why Beth has received constant training to control her powers, a task at which she has excelled. Tell me, what hollow reason would you like to offer up next?"

It had taken some time and cracking through a few false fronts, but before their eyes, the real Haywood Gibson finally appeared. His pleasant face warped into an expression of tight, pinched anger, and he straightened to his full height, which was admittedly taller than either Tori or Ivan. That probably made him feel safe, a reminder that he still had the physical advantage—a delusion that would last only until it was tested, however.

"I'm supposed to just take your word for it, let her in the door because you say it's okay?" The tone was more belligerent now. He was done with diplomacy.

"I would recommend you take the word of the Alliance of Heroic Champions, who has been providing her and others in similar positions with the training," Ivan shot back. "They can produce reports, and did, which I know because we submitted them along with Beth's registration information. But you never read those, did you? You saw the word 'meta' and knew in that moment she wasn't going to be in *your* cluster."

Haywood wisely stayed silent. Implication was one thing; admitting to what he'd done with a witness in the room was another. Ivan just shook his head. "It doesn't matter. I was serious about knowing higher-ups in the organization. Congratulations on your brief tenure as a cluster leader, Mr. Gibson. By tomorrow, the position will be revoked, and I expect you'll be barred from the organization for violating one of its most fundamental tenets. Tori, we can leave now. Our business is concluded."

Not quite looking away yet, Ivan motioned for her to head to the door. Haywood, on the other hand, apparently didn't enjoy being talked down to. He'd gotten redder and redder as Ivan spoke, and Tori could see a vein

bulging along his forehead. After a moment or two to absorb the chewing out, Haywood leaned forward, towering over Ivan.

“Listen here, asshole. I don’t know who you think you are fucking with, but you’ve got no idea the connections I have in this town. Call all the people you want—call Lodestar herself—I’m telling you right now, there is no way I’m going to open my home to your little *abomination* for—”

Tori didn’t see the punch. She could make out the spray of blood that splashed across the desk, and the half-shattered teeth clattering against a wall, she just wasn’t able to track Ivan’s fist as it obliterated Haywood’s jaw. Her whole body went cold, unsure of what the hell was going on. There was no warning, no lead-up, just a savage blow and a now rasping man on the ground, trying to make noise through a mouth no longer shaped for it. With no small measure of fear, Tori looked to Ivan, unsure if it would be him or Fornax who awaited her.

As it turned out, it was Ivan. Purely Ivan. His eyes hadn’t even turned inky and rune-filled, meaning he wasn’t substantially using his powers whatsoever.

That didn’t set her as much at ease as she’d have expected, though. The darkness on Ivan’s face was something Fornax could never match; he didn’t love anything enough to fuel that much hate.

“Since she was a child, Beth has always tried to help those in need. She made a habit of bringing home injured animals, from crushed snails to wounded birds. No matter how many times we told her it was pointless, she kept trying. And when she of course failed, we had to hold a funeral ceremony for each one of those lost souls. Every house I’ve lived in has become a makeshift graveyard, because that girl refuses to walk past when she sees a living being in pain. It’s the same with other children, and people as a whole. That is who my daughter has always been at her core: someone who reaches out to help those in need, no matter how helpless their situation might be. She is so kind, so gentle; every day I am filled with gratitude and pride that she turned out *nothing* like her cruel, petty father.”

With a casual ease, Ivan pressed a foot into Haywood’s ribs, cracking several. “And now, because of something she had no choice in or control over, Beth is going to spend the rest of her life dealing with pieces of shit like you, people who try to take that goodness away from her. Tearing her down for the sin of existing. Telling her she’s different, lesser, that the world doesn’t have a place for her.”

Reaching down, Ivan grabbed Haywood by the neck and lifted him into the air. Whatever illusions the developer had possessed about being stronger than his visitor were long since dispelled. He was visibly cowering now, broken mouth rasping out attempts at screams. As Ivan stared into Haywood's eyes, his own began to change. The irises expanded, swallowing up each eye into a pit of endless darkness. Then, from within the void, red runes began to glow.

If Haywood had been scared before, he was terrified now. His attempts to struggle doubled, and Tori thought she caught the scent of liquid fear emanating from his slacks.

For Ivan, the shifts were irrelevant. He reached up and broke Haywood's left arm in two places.

"Such a shame about the car accident. Crumpled in, really tore up your whole left side. Don't worry, we'll make sure people remember seeing you leave and drive off unharmed. We are exceptionally good at this kind of thing. Because you forgot, Mr. Gibson, that not all metas are capes. We don't all suffer silently and take the higher road. You won't remember this meeting, not truly, but you'll see me in your nightmares. Take this lesson to heart, and carry it with you always."

Ivan pulled Haywood in close until he was mere inches from those deadly glowing eyes. "Some of us fight back. Don't you ever dare forget that, because the next meta might not have my exceptional self-restraint. One last thing: if you ever go near the Starscouts again, in any capacity, I'll rip your fucking limbs off. Filth like you doesn't belong around anything that decent."

Part of Tori wanted to chuckle, but there was nothing funny about the look on Ivan's face. For her part, she took out a cell phone and punched in a familiar number. It was a line all official guild members had to know by heart, and one of the few services that had remained functional during their downtime.

"Yeah, it's me. I think we're going to need a cleanup team. What happened? Ivan got mad. No, not *that* mad. We don't need power washers."

From his position in Ivan's grip, Haywood let out a small squeak of terror before the pain and shock finally sent him into unconsciousness. When he awoke, his memory of acquiring the injuries would be quite different. The eyes would stay with him, though, in his darkest of nightmares. No amount of drugs or drink could drive them away.



Injuries might mend over time, but some wounds burned too deep to heal. Just as Ivan intended.

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## Chapter 6

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Were he forced to explain as simply as possible, Ivan might say the difference between common criminals and villains of the guild was the concept of consequence. Criminals tried to live without them; villains accepted they were inevitable. Leave too much evidence, go to jail. Piss off the capes, end up hunted. Fight Lodestar, lose. Simple, inevitable equations that were easy to ignore in the short-term if one didn't mind losing in the long run.

Villains accepted these facts and were therefore able to work around them. They learned to obliterate their trails, to use the law as a shield, and to avoid getting mixed up with capes. Most of that last one came from just plain avoiding them, making it a point to be where the superheroes weren't. Sometimes, unfortunately, it wasn't that simple. Sometimes, accepting the consequences meant not getting away clean.

Ivan knew what he had to do, just as much as he knew he couldn't let Tori be a part of it.

After a largely silent car ride home, he pulled up in front of the townhouse. "There are several places nearby that deliver. My apologies that we didn't have time to pick something up."

"I... my appetite did well with recovery time, anyway." It was the gentlest way she could broach what had just happened. In the moment, all Ivan had seen was Haywood, but once they turned things over to the cleanup team, he'd realized the experience might have been hard on Tori. She'd witnessed him in the throes of madness, seen him act as a guild enforcer, yet she'd never watched him be so casually violent before.

“What you saw in there... I won’t say I regret it, but I could have sent you from the room first. For that, I’m sorry.”

Tori whipped her head back in surprise. “Whoa now, I think there’s a misunderstanding. Yes, I’m still new enough for bloodshed to make me queasy, but I am on-fucking-board with what just went down. I’m replaying it in my head, subbing in some choice teachers I had who had interesting ideas about what ‘kinds’ of people should go into the sciences. You don’t need to apologize to me for shit. I didn’t call the cops, Ivan. I called a team to wipe up your mess. Let’s not forget, I’m in this guild too.”

She made a good point. In truth, Ivan should be taking her along; she would do well to see this next part. However, that wasn’t his choice to make. The next errand revolved around someone else’s secret. At the very least, he’d try to get the message across. Even if she was no longer his apprentice, Ivan had plenty of experience to share.

“Then you need to remember what comes after an indulgence like that: owning the fallout. Our team will handle the cleanup, but I just hospitalized a Starscout cluster leader a week before they were set to resume meetings. It is on me to go tell my Starscout contacts about the situation and help them make it right. That might mean paying for training the replacement out of pocket, or pitching in with some sort of manual labor at their next event. I could choose not to do that, but it would risk losing those contacts. A villain owns their actions and the consequences that follow.”

After briefly considering the words, Tori popped her door open. “I get it, and I get that these contacts are probably not the kind you bring a new person around. One question, though: how do you know they won’t make you take Haywood’s place?”

“Because they know my *full* history, and I can’t imagine anyone wants Fornax watching over a herd of children.”

“Too bad. If we got a picture of you in the cluster leader uniform, I bet I could make a mint selling those around the guild.”

“It’s the digital age. The Bytes would just scan one and put it on a shared server,” Ivan pointed out.

Tori climbed out of the car before poking her head back in. “Spoilsport. Good luck with your contacts. You know if you need me...”

“I know. Thank you.” With that, Ivan drove off into the night.

Part of Tori was sorely tempted to follow him and see about these mysterious contacts, except she’d just received a very good reminder that

Ivan was not to be tested on some matters. His kids were one of them; the code was another. Besides, after the drive home, she was feeling peckish, and by the time food arrived, Tori would be ravenous.

Whatever he was up to, Ivan could handle himself. Hell, so far as Tori knew, there was only one person in the world who could beat Ivan in a real fight, and what were the odds he'd run into her?



“Yeah, I got the call. Checking on it now.” Dapper Doll clomped along through the rain, cursing her bad fortune to get patrols in a city under a storm cloud. She was ready to get out of Norwalk and back to the comforts of Ridge City—specifically, her dry room and clothes at the AHC. It wasn’t that she minded getting wet for the job—had there been a civilian in need, Dapper Doll would have been racing to their aid. For a simple reconnaissance job involving someone spotting suspicious activity, however, the gusto was harder to conjure.

Stepping down a side street, toward what should have been a building’s rear, filled with dumpsters and perhaps a few people sneaking smokes, Dapper Doll caught sight of movement. Music pulled at her ears, high-pitched and cloying. She slipped closer, thoughts of dryness abandoned. Clangs rose as she moved beneath a section of roof, blocking her momentarily from the rain.

Turning a corner, Dapper Doll couldn’t believe what she saw. Burgers, pizza, fried chicken, hot dogs, cake—an entire smorgasbord of food presented on an immaculately decorated table. Only the food wasn’t lying there, waiting to be eaten. Instead, it was moving around, singing, dancing, and generally partying like there was no tomorrow. Now that she was near, Dapper Doll could see the others watching, entranced: nearly a dozen civilians who must have stumbled upon the show. For a moment, she feared a trap, before noticing the giant banner that hung in the middle of the scene. Emblazoned upon it were three simple words:

“Expect the Unexpected.”

Swallowing hard, Dapper Doll tapped her communicator to radio the office. The higher-ups were definitely going to want to know that Captain Bullshit was active again.



Beverly paused outside the apartment to wipe off her shoes, even though it hadn't rained all day. There had been a massive, stinky puddle to walk through in front of the building, along with a gaggle of smelly, soaked photographers who glared daggers at everyone who strolled inside. They were looking for someone, and having casually glanced at a TV in the last ten hours meant that Beverly knew exactly who. The assholes could wait all night; she'd already gotten a text from Tori that she was crashing at Ivan's place.

Were anyone else she knew staying at the house of an older gentleman they worked for, it would have thrown up a plethora of red flags. Tori and Ivan, thankfully, were a rare exception to the rule. They liked and respected one another, but even ten minutes around the pair made it clear how deeply platonic their relationship was. Beverly was glad for that, especially when Tori needed a place to crash while the guild was down. After this weekend, they'd both have a spot to lay low when the occasion demanded.

Walking into the apartment, Beverly found Chloe standing by the brick wall at the living room's far end, looking out on to the street and the photographers below. "Am I off base in guessing you're the reason all those paparazzi are wet and grumpy?"

"Debatable," Chloe replied. "I just happened to forcefully mention that 'Karma is a bitch' near them. I would argue that after that, anything negative that happened afterward is a consequence of their own choices... including a truck hauling used septic water springing a sudden and brief leak just as it drove past. I also think four of them have stubbed their toes. Guess Karma and I have the same opinion of their profession."

Being part of a guild filled with famous villains, Beverly often marveled at the raw power of her colleagues. Yet Chloe, of all people, worried her even more at times. That ability of hers was easy to underestimate and could have ridiculously potent effects. If it had to end up in anyone's hands, maybe it was best it had gone to neither a cape nor a villain, but to someone who only used the gift casually. And on deserving victims, in this case.

"Isn't septic water...?"

"Yeah, the front stoop needs a serious washing, and you might want to give a scrubbing to any shoes you walked through it with," Chloe confirmed.

“Glad I wiped my feet.” Beverly hunkered down and popped her shoes off, wrapping them in a paper towel to be dealt with once she’d had a moment to relax. “You got Tori’s message, I assume?”

Chloe walked over from the window, turning on the oven and yanking a container from the fridge. “Caught up in a new team’s debut, became a media curiosity, laying low until it blows over. Means there’s one less for dinner.”

“That lucky bum is probably getting home cooking. According to Thu... someone I know, the person she’s staying with is pretty good in a kitchen.”

The statement earned Beverly a look of worried surprise. When they’d moved in with Chloe, she and Tori had been honest about their affiliation to the Guild of Villainous Reformation. It only seemed right, given that living with them exposed her to certain risks, plus Beverly had spilled most of the beans during the “Ridge City Riots” (as most media outlets had dubbed Balaam’s attempted uprising.) Outside of that detail, though, Chloe knew very little of their world. She didn’t ask, they didn’t offer, and the balance had been holding well, so far.

“Sorry, there’s no reason I should find that weird. Everyone eats, so some criminals probably cook well. Just not what I picture when I imagine famous villains, you know? Except for Doctor Mechaniacal, maybe. He always did remind me of a kitchen gadget gone awry.”

Beverly laughed, but said nothing. Neither she nor Tori had told Chloe who’d been their mentors when joining the guild. It wasn’t necessarily a secret, just a topic both took care not to broach accidentally. If Chloe asked, Beverly would answer, for what little that was worth. Her mentor, a surprisingly cultured giant called Thuggernaut, was mostly known as an enforcer who’d gotten on the law’s wrong side—nothing overly shocking. When Chloe found out she was living with Fornax’s apprentice, on the other hand, it might require a longer talk.

That was Tori’s battle, and it could wait for another night. Beverly had her own shit to deal with. But she could also use some rest and entertainment after a long day’s work. “Hey, Chloe, doesn’t the cycling club usually come up the road not too long from now?”

“That they do,” Chloe confirmed.

“I wonder if any of them will accidentally end up on the sidewalk, running over the paparazzi’s feet?” Pouring herself a tall glass of wine,

Beverly walked over to the window and took a spot opposite from where Chloe had been standing, gazing out on the street below.

As it turned out, no cyclists rode on the sidewalk, but one kicked up a spray of stray gravel that got into the eyes of three photographers and broke two cameras. It wasn't until they'd been rubbing their faces for several minutes that someone appeared to remember they were covered in septic water, which led to a mass panic as the three began running around in a tizzy about the impending pink eye.

No doubt about it, Chloe's power was scary as hell.



Things were getting interesting again. The lulls were unavoidable—without a valley, was there such a thing as a peak? Thankfully, just as inevitable was the eventual beginning of something new. So many times he had watched stories like this one, yet they were not quite the same. A shift in details, a difference of characters, all while the bones persisted: new team arrives in town, kicks up a fuss, encounters a stranger that is more than she appears to be.

It wasn't always Tori and Tachyonic. They weren't even always called the New Science Sentries. Sometimes, the debut went bad. Gunfire, people getting hurt, blood everywhere... a lack of real-world experience showing itself in the worst possible way. Those universes were rare, though. Professor Quantum had raised a powerful team, if nothing else. That part almost never changed.

To Nexus, the only things even close to being as interesting as the Singulars—beings who existed in only a single iteration of the multiverse—were those he considered to be Constants. These were fascinating in how little they varied across the infinite sea of possibilities. Lodestar was often a different person—such was the nature of that gift—yet whoever wore the power unfailingly upheld the same standard. That had confused Nexus for a time, until he unraveled the secret of her abilities.

Far more interesting were ones like Professor Quantum. He virtually never changed. In any universe where he existed, he was almost always the same: brilliant, prophetic, and dangerous. Even better, by this point there was usually a dash of desperation mixed in. Alone, that would have made

Professor Quantum a boring target to watch, each iteration being nearly identical. However, although every Professor Quantum was often the same, the worlds they lived in varied tremendously, and that was what made him interesting.

The new team's composition this time was a surprise—Presto often didn't make the cut. This one was either talented or determined. Nexus could hardly wait to see which it would be as he sat on the roof-deck of Tori's building, enjoying the late-summer evening heat. Already, the gears were turning, old grudges rising. It was shaping up to be one hell of a show this time around. And it would be, no matter what.

Things were going to be interesting soon, even if Nexus had to *make* them interesting.



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## Chapter 7

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“To be clear, your story is that you came by my home to tell me one of the Starscout cluster leaders was keeping a meta-human child, your daughter, out of her established group, and that said leader was also involved in a terrible car accident that will remove him from the role. The two things are, I’m supposed to believe, an unrelated coincidence. Good god, Ivan, you couldn’t have brought this in when I was putting Penelope to bed? She loves a good piece of fiction.”

The kitchen table was tense as Helen and Ivan both nursed their cups of coffee. As far as these sorts of talks went, it hadn’t been a terrible one. She’d heard him out and hadn’t interrupted, even during the section they both knew to be utter falsehood. Once the story was over, though, Helen had gotten a serious look in her eyes. She’d left the room briefly, made a few calls, and returned with a sense of purpose. Ivan had no idea what to expect when she put on that expression, only that she’d be the one to decide the next step.

“I’ll ask out of obligation, is there any chance that I could find evidence to prove this wasn’t just a car accident?”

“I can’t imagine why you would. Ask the man himself. He’ll tell you he got distracted on the road and spun out, eventually slamming into a tree. Not only is there a lack of evidence, there is, technically speaking, no crime to investigate.”

Wordlessly, Helen finished her coffee, walked to the counter, poured a fresh cup, and then proceeded to dump in more fake sugars than Ivan could fathom before returning to her seat. Her holographic-generating glasses

were perched on the side of the table, meaning that she looked her physical age at the moment. Somehow, watching what should be a nineteen year old with such a world-weary gaze always unnerved him slightly.

Ivan sat patiently as she worked, wondering what would come next. This was new ground for them. Part of her had to know these things happened, yet normally, Ivan kept it miles from her radar. Tonight was different; he'd messed with something of *hers*.

"Ivan, do you know the origins of the Starscouts?" Helen spoke after three test sips from her new cup of coffee.

"I recall the general shape of the tale," Ivan replied. "A pair of siblings accidentally kicked up a fuss when one wanted to join the Junior League of Heroes, Professor Quantum's old child-meta indoctrination ring, and the other was barred entry for being human. When they switched over, both attempting to join the Kid Adventurers, they found out that that organization didn't allow metas. In the media firestorm that followed, a new company wanted to start something to capitalize on the opportunity, but they were competing with established institutions, so they needed a big draw. The sort of face no one could ignore. They found her, but she demanded more than just certain humans and metas be allowed in. Lodestar watches over everyone, so every child was welcome in her organization. That was the deal if they wanted to use her as a spokeswoman."

Another sip from the cup. "This jerk isn't the first to try to break my promise. There are systems in place for that sort of thing. Whatever insult he hurled to get under your skin, you would have won out in the end. But from what I'm hearing, he got the absolute hell beaten out of him. These aren't the old days, Ivan. You can't go around punching everyone who annoys or—"

"He called my daughter an abomination. You want to throw me back into Rookstone, go right ahead. We both know you can do it. But the Earth will rot and the sun will die before I ever apologize for what I did tonight."

The serious veneer slipped slightly, revealing a shocked expression on Helen's face. "I wasn't expecting that."

"Thought better of me?" Ivan asked.

"Worse. I assumed if he'd crossed a line like that, you'd have killed him outright." Helen leaned back in her chair, hands absentmindedly drumming on the cup. "For goodness' sake, Ivan, you always keep things moving, I'll give you that. What am I supposed to do with this? We both know you

broke the law, but I've got no provable victim, not even a crime to report. Capes aren't judge or jury outside of dire emergencies, and without proof, I'd just be wasting time and resources trying to pin you for this."

He didn't have an easy answer to give. This was the trouble with having friends on the other side. Sooner or later, it made things complicated. Although in the case of he and Helen, it had definitely been sooner. "It is a dilemma. If I can offer something to help make it right, I will."

Helen hopped off her chair again, this time going to a different section of the kitchen and returning with a bottle of dark rum. She poured a shot into her remaining coffee, then offered it to Ivan, who also accepted. Neither of them could get drunk off such a paltry offering; it was the act of drinking together that held significance.

"Here's the situation as I see it. You hurt a civilian tonight. Maybe one who had it coming, but still, you hurt a mundane. It's one thing when criminals fight one another—not even Lodestar can protect people from their own choices. Civilians are different; you of all people know that. You can't skate on this, Ivan. That said, you handled it the best way I could have hoped for, coming right over and reading me in on the situation, even being honest when pushed. It's possible, if I spent a *tremendous* amount of resources that would be better used elsewhere, that I *might* be able to get the courts to prosecute you for assault. Not a great option. So instead, we'll do this one off the books. No cops, no jail. You're serving *my* sentence. Can you handle that?"

Some might have jumped at the opportunity. Not Ivan. He stared into his coffee-cocktail, pondering the offer for a full minute before finally offering a reply. "I won't betray anyone who has put their trust in me. If the penance requires me to turn on the guild or other allies, then I'm afraid I must decline."

It was Helen's turn to think, though she didn't need as long. "I'm almost completely certain my idea won't cause you to do that; however, if it comes up, we can agree to deal with it on a case-by-case basis."

With resigned determination, Ivan nodded. "Then I will abide by the punishment you decide."

"Good." Helen pulled out her phone and began to text. "I'm sending over some details. You'll need to go pick up a uniform before next week, plus review the information and resource packet long before the meeting. I don't care how dorky the uniform looks; you're wearing it."

The whiplash was so severe that not even Ivan's augmented body could bear it. His head swam as talk shifted from punishment to doing some sort of errand. It was only when Ivan looked at the text Helen sent that the pieces fell into place.

"You can't be serious. The other parents would throw a fit if they knew."

"They *will* know. They'll know that Ivan Gerhardt stepped in to take over as cluster leader after a supposedly unrelated car accident sidelined the current one. And since they all think of Ivan as a pillar of the community and a loving parent—a view I share—they'll have no objections to you filling the role." Helen was grinning a little now, making a half-effort to hide the smile behind her coffee cup. "Besides, you don't have to do it alone. Every Starscout cluster has a male and female leader, so you'll get someone at your side to help."

Ivan took a heftier drink, wishing he'd put more rum in the coffee. "I can only imagine what poor soul will be trapped with me as a partner."

"Seeing as Haywood's helper was going to be a secretary from his office, she's pulled out along with him," Helen said. "Don't worry. I already know a perfect sub. Great woman, won't take any of your shit, and has one hell of a hand at a crafting table."

"*You*? You're going to be a Starscout cluster leader? Isn't that a tad... self-indulgent?"

"Solid point. I'll let some other gal unknowingly pair up with a legendary supervillain to take care of a bunch of children." The smile faded slightly, her eyes growing firm once more. "Look, making you clean up after yourself is the best idea I have that doesn't involve a wild goose chase of investigation, but I also owe a responsibility to those kids. While you've got your talents, I think they'll do better with someone a little more personable, as well. So I'm going to help, because although you are a criminal and fast with the punches, you're also my friend."

It was a touching moment, cut short as she quickly added, "Oh, and Tori is going to be joining us as well."

The cup nearly shattered in Ivan's hand, his tension in the moment the only thing that left him aware enough to stop the reaction of surprise. "Why would we do that? On top of putting your identity at needless risk, Tori and I have roughly the same level of personal skills. Even Wade said as much

when he paired us together, calling us both pains in the ass. I don't imagine that improves around children."

"She's not coming because we need the help. She's coming to get the lesson. Tori was with you during all of this, so she needs to see that even Fornax has to face the consequences of his actions."

Although he'd marshalled himself as she spoke, Ivan was still feeling unnerved. "How did you know about... never mind, I suppose it doesn't matter. Tori had no hand in the night's events. She was there only because she couldn't go home, thanks to an AHC cape putting her in the spotlight."

"Tachyonic and the others are already working on making right their mistakes. We're talking about you." There was a sternness to Helen's tone that made it clear she wasn't negotiating; however, it had softened slightly by the time she spoke again. "I assumed Tori was a bystander already, which is why I'm giving her the same role. She's going to be our assistant—or accomplice, as some might call it—just like she was tonight. Besides, I think it's time to meet your apprentice, especially now that she's tied to the New Science Sentries."

"What am I supposed to tell her about why, exactly, she suddenly has to start joining us for Starscout meetings?"

"I'd go with the truth," Helen suggested. "You're making amends and need her help. If she really pushes, you could tell her that the orders came from Lodestar herself."

Ivan's eyes widened in terror as he imagined taking that route. "I'll think of something else. That sort of statement raises more questions than it answers, and Tori's curiosity is already a dangerous thing. I'd hate to see it piqued in your direction." He glanced over, expecting professional interest and instead finding a sly smirk of excitement.

"I like her already. Now, let's dig into the Starscout meeting structure. You might want to grab a pen."



A secret, high-tech, guild-funded base this was not. The building had been a manufacturing plant for cheap plastic novelties that went belly-up a few decades back, then got further developed by a tech startup to use as a hip new office. Sadly, they also went bankrupt—in this case, before the

renovation was even complete. The result of this was a strange, cavernous building with an unusual number of empty rooms, giant production machines covered in grime and dust, as well as the rare and wonderful luxury of working toilets.

The crew gathered around Deacon, whose eyes were shining brightly. Nobody was sure if Deacon was really a meta, like he claimed, or if he was just a smart guy with ambition and guts. His thin frame might have made him an easy target in a different organization, but a benefit of being the mastermind was that no one expected physical intimidation to be in his repertoire. Besides, that was why Darius stood on the opposite side of Emory, both of them flanking Deacon, sending the clear message that he wasn't alone. While Deacon might not really be a meta-genius like he claimed, he was certainly smart enough to keep his bodyguards well compensated.

Darius was a standard bruiser, the sort of strong, tough meta one could find without much effort. He was a little older than some, which presented vulnerabilities, but also experience. Thus far, he'd been a useful asset to Deacon. Hell, a good chunk of this gang had been found through Darius's contacts. Emory himself was less bulky, yet substantially more unnerving. Scales on his gray-green skin gave away his condition before one could notice the sharp claws on his hand or the fangs in his mouth. Good as Darius was at handling the straightforward threats, some challenges called for a more flexible solution.

After a couple of weeks working for Deacon, Emory had begun to get a sense of the man. The talk had been going for five minutes already, and as he watched Deacon's posture straighten, Emory realized they were finally getting to the meat of the matter.

"—and so, you see, fate has offered us a rare chance. Thanks to today's events, we have an opportunity to do something few would ever dream. We can gain the advantage over a group of *superheroes*. Imagine it: grabbing a woman they've only just publicly saved and holding her hostage. For the life of a civilian, the superheroes will bend over backward."

From the back, a hand went up, followed quickly by the man shouting his question. "Won't one of the big capes just come save her?"

There was a murmur of agreement among the masses. No one had forgotten seeing the capes kick ass across Ridge City not so long ago, a solid reminder of what made them dangerous.

“A fair point, and one I considered myself. Worry not, I have a lead on some components that will render us impossible to find for even the most gifted of metas,” Deacon assured him. “As for dealing with our targets, do not fret. We will conduct this operation in such a way that the New Science Sentries’ own shame will keep them from seeking outside help, keeping our opponents’ numbers manageable. They will try to deal with us themselves, and in the process, become even more vulnerable.”

Another voice rang from the back. “How does this get us paid?”

The murmurs were much louder this time. Good plans or not, Deacon wasn’t winning over this crowd without a dollar sign.

Apparently, he’d been ready for this, continuing without so much as a second of hesitation.

“A smart question to ask before any job. The answer is simple: we get paid for the act of committing the crime. Our talents have been recognized, and the employer is extremely interested in the New Science Sentries. We are not to kill any of them, but injuries will be highly rewarded, as will unmasking any members.”

One of the less-public aspects of Emory’s power was the gift of smelling emotions. Not every twinge in sentiment flung scents into the air, but the major ones usually came coupled with detectable pheromones. That was why Emory noticed the sting of fear across his nostrils at those words. Wordlessly, three of the criminals turned and walked out of the building without so much as a second thought.

“Don’t worry about them,” Darius assured Deacon softly. “Plenty in this line of work have a no-AHC policy. They won’t run their mouth, but they aren’t touching this sort of job regardless of pay.”

In different circumstances, Deacon might have ordered them killed. The problem was that all three were connections of Darius, who would most likely get the execution order. If he said no, or stopped Emory from doing the job, Deacon’s entire power structure would collapse—that much he was certainly smart enough to see.

“Very well. A greater split of the pay for us.”

Deacon went back into his spiel, but Emory kept an eye on Darius. It wasn’t him coaching a peaceful solution that was strange; Darius usually erred on the side of diplomacy. No, what bothered Emory was the continuing scent of fear.

The strongest source hadn't left with the others. In fact, it was standing opposite him, guarding the other side of Deacon. Why was Darius so afraid of this plan? What did he and those three seem to know that the rest of them didn't?

Most important of all: why weren't they sharing this concern with anyone else?



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## Chapter 8

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An unexpected silver lining to Tori's sudden minor celebrity status was Vendallia making the call to let her work remotely for the rest of the week. That, or Wade put word through his channels and made it happen. One could never be sure how much influence that man exerted in his company, which, to Ivan's thinking, was exactly the way he liked it.

Pulling up to the Vendallia building, Ivan noted a person hanging out near the entrance. A frown tugged at his neutral expression, trying and failing to coax emotion onto his face. Security was supposed to keep the paparazzi away from the building, since this was privately owned property. This one must have been especially dedicated and foolhardy. Ivan would ensure the mistake wasn't repeated, not at *his* place of work.

Halfway across the parking lot, a familiar flash of copper hair triggered Ivan's memory. It couldn't be... could it? Given that he'd been living at the AHC all this time, the level of change was certainly possible. This man stood straighter and had noticeably more mass, but there was no mistaking Donald Moss. Technically speaking, he was still on the Vendallia payroll, though his deliverables had shrunk to a token level. It had been quite a few weeks since Ivan last laid eyes on his former programmer.

"Mr. Moss, to what do we owe this unexpected honor?" Ivan didn't bother to scan him into the building—not because he felt a need to keep Donald out, but because he suspected the man's reason for visiting wasn't here. "If you've come to check on Tori, I'm afraid she won't be present today. In light of the traumatic events, Vendallia is permitting her to work from home and stay out of the public view."

Even though Donald flushed at the assumption, Ivan knew he'd saved them both five minutes of Donald beating around the bush. This was still a workday, presumably for both of them. Cyber Geek patrolled a lot of local beats with his team; the AHC was helping them lay a good foundation of experience in a place where they still had veteran capes watching. It was hard to miss his antics, and Ivan was glad to see the young man finding his place.

"I wanted to make sure she was okay. And to apologize. Tachyonic isn't on my team, but he's part of the AHC, so it seemed like one of us should say we're sorry about all this."

As a villain, even a barely-involved one, Ivan was grateful Donald hadn't ended up with a more... potent ability. When people with these kinds of noble instincts got serious power, they made being a villain all the harder. To his thinking, there were enough capes like that already, and one *real* superhero spurring them on to greater heights.

"Very responsible of you, Donald. I'll pass the message along—unless you intend to reach out to her today?"

"I might send over a text. Thought it would be better to apologize in person, but I guess digital beats nothing." Donald paused, all pretense of their meeting exhausted. Not wanting to seem like he'd only come for Tori, Donald groped about for small talk. "How have you been, Mr. Gerhardt?"

"Healthy and busy. On that regard, if you'd like to visit socially, I'm happy to make time. However, I'm afraid the day's tasks are currently calling." It was best to put this conversation out of its misery. They both had better uses for their day.

Donald appeared to agree, hurrying away from the door to clear Ivan's way. "Of course! Sorry to bother you, Mr. Gerhardt."

Before he turned away fully, Ivan spoke up once more. "You're never a bother, Donald. I daresay many in the office miss your presence, myself included. They're all very proud of you. If you were to go up and look through the breakroom, I think you'd be surprised just how many of the mugs are emblazoned with Cyber Geek's branding."

The look between them stretched on for several seconds before Donald gave a slow nod. "Thanks, Mr. Gerhardt. You know, you're one of the only people who didn't look at me differently after everyone found out what I could do."

“I have always known the kind of man you are. Gaining powers merely offered you a new way to show that to the world. So long as you remember why you took this path, you never need to feel ashamed about who you are.”

Another long look, this one ending with an unexpected smile before Donald finally walked away. Any other day, Ivan would have left out that last part, but the memory of Haywood’s words from the prior night still rang in his ears. He could offer a little extra comfort to a fellow meta-human, even if Donald would likely never know it was a bond they shared.



Didn’t it fucking figure? The morning prior, Tori would have said she’d trade anything to have the rest of the week off to tweak her suit. Now, she had the time, and one of the only places she couldn’t spend it was at her apartment building where the suit was waiting. Plus, in the process of getting her free week, Tori had lost one of her most valuable assets as a villain: anonymity. In her civilian form, she was supposed to be no one of significance—the sort of person eyes would skim right past without another thought.

As she helped herself to Ivan’s fridge, noting that he’d stocked some of her favorite beer, Tori mulled over the idea that while anonymity was her teacher’s tactic, it wasn’t the only one. Wade Wyatt himself proved that point perfectly. Unbeknownst to the rest of the world, famed billionaire investor and entrepreneur Wade Wyatt was really the famous supervillain known as Doctor Mechaniacal. True, everyone did still think of him as a criminal, but only in the ways that capitalism forgave by necessity. Even his most vicious of critics couldn’t fathom who they were really talking about.

The more she dwelled on the notion, idly sorting through emails on her laptop in case someone decided to make sure she was putting in the hours, the more Tori began to consider that this might have been inevitable. If she wanted to follow Wade’s path, found her own company to sell her tech, then Tori would be a public figure eventually.

Perhaps this could be more than ill-fortune. Notoriety had rewards along with risks. Opening a new browser, Tori brought up old articles on Wade Wyatt’s rise to prominence. With an example to pull from and an

opportunity to use, she might be able to turn this development to her advantage. Unfortunately, anything she tried would require charisma to pull off, which posed a challenge. When it came to technology and data, Tori spoke the language fluently. Interacting with people had never come as easily. Her best friendships had come from either trying to pretend to be something she wasn't (a normal office drone) or had been forged in the heat of battles with life-or-death stakes.

A problem to tackle down the line, she supposed. Right now, she needed to flesh out this half-formed idea while she still had the shape of it. If nothing else, it was something to fill up her day. She'd stretch her legs for lunch, but until then, Tori waded deep into the waters of the last few decades of meta-human history.



The scrawny boy appeared to be no more than eleven years old, which made the half-drunk glass of warm beer in front of him rather worrying. Stranger still was the way everyone inside the fetid building gave him a wide berth, save only for the waitstaff, who would occasionally venture near to refresh his beverage. Only two other patrons lingered—a pair of men in fatigues with prominently displayed weapons, both nursing a liquor that was bitter and potent.

A new shadow appeared in the door, the person who stepped through causing audible gasps from staff who happened to look over. She was unnaturally tall and thin, like her skin wasn't holding in quite as many organs and muscles as a normal human's might. Skin tinged the color of an old lime, hairless, she moved with dangerous grace, like a cougar roaming the brush. Despite the heat, most of her body, save for her arms, legs, and head, were concealed under a large purple coat with an absurd amount of buttons.

From his spot at the bar, the lone child briefly glanced over, then motioned to a waitress, tapping the empty space at his side. Within moments, another beer was waiting, appearing seconds before the strange woman took her seat.

"You shouldn't be here. We talked about this when we ran. At least, those of us who were sane enough to string words together. Scatter to the

winds and lay low for as long as we can. Too many of us gather, the wrong people take notice, and next thing you know, *she'll* be kicking down that door and dragging us back.”

His voice was appropriate to his appearance, plainly that of a child. Yet there was a worn quality to it as well, the tone of one who had seen a lifetime of sunsets and still had untold more to go. He appraised his unexpected guest as her unnaturally long fingers plucked the glass from the table and she slurped some of the contents.

“I have never understood your taste for squalor, Grantham.” Her voice, like the rest of her, was a little off. Too high in places, too low in others, like someone doing an impression of human speech. “You are correct. Initially, our plan was to spread ourselves thin and stay hidden. Some have been making bolder moves since then. Blade God cut through an entire underground weapons dealer’s warehouse hunting for a clue on his swords. Suh-Rak is gathering components for another summoning, some of Cobblord’s labyrinths are showing up for sale again, and of course, no one knows what to expect next from Captain Bullshit. Not to mention there were rumors of some mythically powerful frost Viking killing a warlord’s army and placing the entire encampment under his control.”

At her words, a new tension filled the room. Every person there stopped, waiting to see what the child’s reaction would be. It turned out to be finishing his beer and motioning for another. Grantham faced his guest fully as he waited for the refill.

“Come to scold me, Lozora? I didn’t kill off some benevolent village leader or anything like that. I tore a criminal’s head off, froze it, and put it on display as a warning to whoever tried next. That’s how it works, right? We get to do what we want so long as we hurt other criminals? That’s how they justified letting fucking Fornax out into the world, isn’t it?”

Grantham slammed a fist on the word “Fornax,” striking the bar and causing a thin sheet of ice to form along its top. He took a moment to compose himself, then allowed the bartender to set down his next beer. “If the AHC knew about this place, they would have come already.”

“Not even superheroes can keep control over the entire world, but I suspect the AHC will make time for us, should they learn of our positions. You remember Captain Bullshit’s warning: he has made us nigh impossible to find, but that protection fades once we reveal ourselves publicly, intentionally or otherwise.”

Despite the snort that escaped his lips, Grantham had no doubt the protection was real. It was the only explanation for how, in this new, digital age, not a single escaped criminal from Rookstone had been caught yet. Besides that, Captain Bullshit's power was held in high regard. Were it in the hands of someone a little more focused, they might very well be the greatest meta in existence.

"That's why you came all the way out here? To remind me that I need to be careful?"

"No. I came because there might be another way. Someone is making covert hires at the moment. They are funding everything from street-level enterprises to recruiting specialists of our level. I can't say more at this juncture, but trust me when I say it is someone with experience."

Sipping off the top of his drink, Grantham smacked his lips. He had to go into the damn tropics to manage it, but here the natural aura of cold put off by his body was dulled enough to allow for warm drinks to touch his lips. It didn't seem like much, until the ten thousandth time a hot meal turned lukewarm the moment it hit his tongue.

"I'm not bending a knee to that guild. Call themselves villains all they like, but once you've got rules on you, you're a cog in the machine, same as everyone else. Been a cog once. Not going back to that."

Lozora shook her unnatural head. "Not the guild. Not anyone who's been inside Rookstone, actually."

Now *that* got Grantham's attention. "I thought she'd rounded up all the major players."

"There was a long time before her, before the AHC. Some enemies are older, smarter, and more patient. The largest, most fearsome alligators are the ones cunning enough to avoid hunters year after year. One of them is hiring, if that interests you."

For a few minutes, there was no sound save for the occasional slurps of warm beer. At last, Grantham set his glass down, slowly shaking his head.

"Nah. I'm gonna pass. I know where this ends for me: in battle. Always in battle. I've only been out for a little while; I'd like to enjoy myself some more. Give the mystery employer my best, and let them know if something really interesting pops up, I won't automatically kill an envoy—even if they aren't as fearsome as you."

"As expected. I cautioned them as much, but it was essential to try. Having the legendary Jokull on staff is the sort of opportunity that cannot

be passed over.”

Grantham’s face tightened briefly, causing all the nearby staff to scamper back, but it relaxed seconds later. “No Jokull these days unless he’s necessary. Luckily, he hasn’t been needed since the last attempted insurrection. I think word has finally spread that shooting me while I’m like this only brings him forth.”

The pair of armed men on the other side of the hut exchanged sudden, fearful looks, then walked out as casually as they were able. Given the clanks of weaponry as they moved, it was not a particularly successful endeavor.

With a weary sigh, Grantham moved to rise from his seat, until Lozora’s hand fell on his shoulder. “Allow me. I’m heading out, anyway. A token of thanks, for your hospitality.”

Her long legs unfurled as she stood, making it out of the bar in a smattering of steps. Seconds later, Grantham heard the telltale thud of weighted bodies dropping into the dirt. That was Lozora—when she decided it was time to strike, most never even had a chance to scream.

Part of Grantham was curious to see where her endeavor would lead, but he’d been at this too long to jump at the first offer. Best to wait and let the real schemers get their plans in order. That was what would lead to a fight worth having.

*That was when Jokull would return.*

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## Chapter 9

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Thursday evening was an unexpectedly busy one in Ivan's townhome. Between having a cluster of Starscouts to prepare for next week and a clandestine organization of criminals reopening that weekend, Ivan was swamped. Some of the work had spilled over onto Tori, who was finding herself dealing with uncomfortable levels of nostalgia as she worked through the old Starscout materials.

Just as the sun was going down, Ivan got a call that had him leave the room. That in itself was par for the course; when they'd been living together, Tori had seen Ivan seek solitude for calls from Vendallia, the guild, and his kids. The man enjoyed his privacy. This time, however, he came back with an expression that was hard to read. Ivan always looked a little too serious for any given situation, yet this was different. Worry, she'd seen enough of on his visage to catch, but unless she was mistaken, there was a small twinkle of amusement in his eyes. It was the sort of potentially dangerous tell she'd learned to watch for years ago.

"I am pleased to announce that you are officially cleared to return to your apartment. The paparazzi gave up faster than we expected. Seems the ones who camped out always had an especially bad time, and the countermeasures to ensure your safety have been put into place. You're free to head over as soon as you like."

"Uh huh. And are we just going to skim past the word 'countermeasures' like that's not some shit I should be read in on?" Tori paused her current work-in-progress—cutting out a few dozen cardboard



circles that would be part of a crafting project for the Starscouts. “You’ve got a look about you. Is this something I should be concerned with?”

While it might have been Tori’s imagination, Ivan seemed to smile slightly, just for a sliver of a second. “Yes, it is, but if I were to forewarn you, it might complicate things further. The wheels are in motion. It’s not in our power to stop without experiencing serious repercussions. But the countermeasures were put in place by someone I trust, so in the end, I have faith that they’ll prove useful.”

If it was someone Ivan trusted, then that narrowed down the pool substantially. Outside of his kids, the only people Ivan seemed to trust were some of his fellow guild council members. The most likely candidate was Doctor Mechaniacal, except anything he added to the building, they all knew Tori would find and take apart. Maybe someone with magic, the polar opposite of her specialty. Arcanicus was on the council now and had stayed loyal to the guild during that nasty Balaam business. That made the most sense, and magic was weird, so it could account for why her knowing in advance would matter.

“Doesn’t seem like I have much choice in the matter.”

“You could move,” Ivan suggested. “Get a more secure place, and we’ll have our people protect the records so the new home wouldn’t slip out. Not pleasant, but sometimes, that is the best solution.”

It was true. She had no real attachment to the apartment; they’d only been there a few months. Except... this was the first home she’d *chosen* in a long time. Not a base, or a hideout, or a shelter: a home. Ivan’s garage apartment had been a nice stepping stone, but this was different. No one was driving her out until Tori was ready to go.

Besides, it would take too long to get a new lab up and running.

Tori brushed the shards of cardboard from her hands as she stood. “Fuck that. I’m not going anywhere. In fact, if you don’t mind, I’d like to head over. I’ve got some last-minute suit work I can pack in before things kick off this weekend.”

“I understand the sentiment to stay planted a little too well,” Ivan replied. “By all means. I appreciate the help you’ve already given. Go home, get *some* rest if you can manage it, and I’ll see you after work tomorrow.”

Tomorrow. The guild reopened tomorrow. It wasn’t like Tori had some grand scheme to rob a stock exchange cooking in the back of her mind, yet

she'd been surprised to find that once the Guild of Villainous Reformation had vanished from her life, she suddenly missed it. That was especially strange, given how she'd found her way into it, but she couldn't deny the flutter of excitement in her chest at the thought of tomorrow. Some of the world's most powerful, deadly people would be gathered together, making small talk, and Tori would be right there with them.

No, actually, that wasn't quite right. Hephaestus would be the one in attendance, which was all the more reason Tori needed to get to work. She couldn't very well show up to an event like that in unkempt attire. Beverly would have her head on a platter.

"I'll be there with bells on. Well, with *some* kind of metal covering on."

Ivan groaned, but Tori was almost positive she caught a hint of chuckle in there as well.



The people walking past the newspaper box paid it no mind. These metal contraptions lingered despite their less frequent use, gravestones for print media even as it desperately grasped at the last vestiges of life. It was old, faded green, and had a dent on one side from an enthusiastic teen with a steel-toed boot. There was nothing of note about it, until there was.

No one could say where the package came from. A box, white as a page, bound with a ribbon the shade of purple that reminded those who saw the hue why purple was the color of royalty. The ribbon ended in crisp bow with a single end poking out. One tug is all it would take to undo the immaculate ribbon, and upon seeing it, every possessor of hands in the vicinity wanted to be the one to make that tug.

It was a child who was there first, her line of sight and position allowing her to reach the prize before anyone else. For curiosity's sake, that was ideal. An adult would have had considerations, hesitations, thoughts and fears that would have stayed their hands. Children had no such hurdles to clear. When it came to presents, there was an immediate and optimal strategy: open it.

The ribbon gave with a single pull, fluttering lightly to the ground. Fast she could, the girl slipped a thumb under that pristine lid and yanked it up. For an instant, the box seemed empty. Not as if there was nothing inside,

but rather as if it contained a vast and endless void, a chasm in existence through which one could slip and be lost forever. Then, from within that void came a voice that burst forth, thundering throughout the entire street.

“Expect the unexpected!”

A squeal broke from the girl’s lips as birds burst out of the box, which she quickly dropped and ran away from. They were all species and colors, an avian enthusiast’s dearest dream made manifest. So many, too many; the rainbow of wings began to blot out the sky, the roar of their flaps drowning out all other sounds. Within seconds, it was too loud to talk, the world growing dim as more and more birds sealed it off from the sun. Only when the sky was fully blanketed did the flapping stop.

No warning. One minute, all of the street in downtown Dash City was under birds. The next, they suddenly halted their wings. Rather than fall, every bird began to expand, growing, inflating, and finally bursting entirely. Rather than the expected rain of blood and viscera, each bird produced only a small puff of something in their demise.

Like the birds themselves, the strange puffy materials ranged the color spectrum, drifting down to cover everything below. It was once more a child who discovered this material’s true nature, knowing it on sight and popping it into their mouth before a very worried parent could stop them.

Cotton candy. The birds were exploding into cotton candy, which was now coating the street like a sugary snowstorm. It was bizarre, nonsensical, and disturbing on multiple levels. Only the younger people in attendance actually needed that signature line at the beginning. The rest had been around long enough to know a Captain Bullshit production when they saw one.



The car, piloted by one of Wade’s robotic drivers, dropped Tori off at the curb before her building. While there were no cameras or reporters there as Tori yanked her bag of clothes and sundries from the trunk, she did have to deal with a large moving van blocking off most of the front entrance. It was thanks to that van that she didn’t notice Beverly and Chloe coming up from the other side of the street, nearly colliding with the pair.

“Oh hey, Tori’s back just in time.” Chloe held up a large bag filled with to-go containers from a nearby noodle shop. “Beverly said you’d be here. This is pretty quick, though.”

“I got a text you were on your way just when we were ordering.” Beverly’s stare was harder than necessary, most likely because Tori hadn’t been the one to send any sort of message. It had no doubt come from Ivan, possibly relayed through another guild member like Thuggernaut.

Tori ignored the stare, reaching over instead to take one of Chloe’s plastic bags. “Must have caught the good traffic. You two got dumplings, right?” Her eyes were scanning the bag, hunting for any container that might have the proper dimensions.

“Somehow, we remembered your favorite dish from the place we eat at weekly.” Beverly threw an arm around Tori as they headed into the building, squeezing her tight. “I’m glad to see you’re okay. Curious about why they let you come back so soon, but that’s probably a discussion for closed doors.”

All three climbed the stairs, reaching their floor—the third—in short order. Here, however, they encountered a dilemma. Stretching out from the door two apartments down from their own was a giant couch. It was caught at an awkward angle, slightly too long to make the door’s corner as it came in from the hallway. Since it wasn’t able to go in, that left a hunk of furniture jutting out into the hall, blocking anyone from getting past. Even more odd was that this sizable couch was being held up by one man. Since his back was to them, they could only make out his substantial frame and golden hair.

“Austin, would you try pushing now? *Gently!*”

There was something familiar about that voice, something in the cadence. Tori couldn’t place it, though, and in seconds, she had something new to occupy her interest. In front of them, the big man shifted his weight, moving the couch slightly forward.

*Snap.*

“What was that?” The man holding the couch was the one yelling this time. There was a casual ease to his voice, an exact opposite of the tightly wound tone they’d heard coming from the apartment. It was strangely soothing and oddly calm, given the situation.

“One more thing to fix, apparently. Hang on. Ike’s going to grab a screwdriver, then Ellie and I will take the door off its hinges. Just... give me

a minute.”

Since everyone involved in the move seemed content to wait, Tori loudly cleared her throat. Unloading a cumbersome couch was hardly a sin, but she wanted to get to dinner while it was hot. After so many days away from home, hitting a snag mere steps from the door was especially infuriating.

At the sound of her voice, the man holding the couch—presumably Austin—turned to face them. He was handsome, a classic chin paired with shaggy hair and eyes that were a tad too blue. Those eyes took in the scene, then stopped, suddenly.

Without warning, the couch went slamming to the ground with a worryingly loud thud. Tori braced for a charge, expecting some enemy that had slipped in and was about to ambush them. The attack never came. Instead, she realized that Austin had begun to blush and was hurriedly trying to pick the couch back up over the cries of protest from inside the apartment. Had he been holding that thing up on his own, and from the back end?

“My apologies, ladies—I mean, ma’ams, er... my apologies. We got caught up in the task at hand and I didn’t notice your arrival. Give me a moment, and I’ll make some space.”

While Austin was fumbling with the couch, acting strangely weak given what they’d all seen him do, new faces poked out from the doorway. The first was lean, with brown hair and serious eyes. Next was another blonde, this one female, and made up like she had somewhere fancy to be. Lastly was the lowest in the doorframe, a shorter fellow with a mischievous grin already in place.

“Oh! It’s you.” The woman, Ellie by process of elimination, stared right at Tori for a full three seconds before the dark-haired man next to her gave a quick elbow. “I mean, it’s you, our down-the-hall neighbors.”

“Either that, or you picked the worst time to come tour one of the available units.” When he spoke, the lean one confirmed himself to be the owner of the tightly wound voice. Most of that vanished as he stepped forward, however, adopting a far more relaxed demeanor. “Sorry about the bad first impression. I’m Kyle, the lunk handling most of the couch is Austin, the guy next to me is Ike, and that just leaves Ellie.”

Beverly took charge of their end, sparing Tori and Chloe the trouble. “I’m Beverly. This is Tori and Chloe. You all seem nice, but we’ve got hot

food we'd like to eat soon, so if it's not too much trouble, could you make a gap that we can squeeze past?"

At Beverly's words, Austin had stopped working entirely, but the moment her request was verbalized, he sprang into action. Another loud *snap* echoed from within the apartment as Austin hurriedly jammed the couch into a new angle, this one offering enough clearance for a person to fit through. Although Tori saw Kyle wince at the noise, he said nothing.

"Thanks... Austin, wasn't it?" Beverly paused as she walked past. "When we're not in such a hurry, I'll bring these two over and we'll do proper introductions."

"That sounds lovely." Despite the fact that she and Chloe were right on Beverly's heels, Austin's attention hovered on them cursorily, only flickering their way long enough to ensure they made it through the gap safely. The rest of the time, his eyes seemed to be at war with themselves, trying to look at Beverly, then stopping and jerking away.

Without any further delays, Tori and the others made their way into the apartment. While Chloe went about unpacking the bags, Tori and Beverly took a short detour into Tori's bedroom. Not every part of the apartment could be adequately isolated on a budget, but Tori had spent the extra cash to equip her room with dampening tech. It wouldn't stop Professor Quantum from listening in; however, any bug off the street would get nothing but static.

Walking briskly into her room, Tori shut the door, and then flicked some hidden switches on her nightstand. Spinning around, she motioned to Beverly that it was okay to talk. A good thing, because the words came bursting from Beverly's mouth the moment they were permitted.

"It's not just me, right? That has to be them... except, how? How did they end up here, in our building, on our floor? And seriously, do they really think they're hiding it?"

All prudent questions, but Tori decided to tackle the confirmation that Beverly was, in fact, correct in her suspicion.

"It's not just you. That was definitely the New Science Sentries. For some reason, we're now living down the hall from the AHC's newest team of capes."

Perhaps she should have given more thought to moving after all.

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## Chapter 10

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“Is there any chance we’re wrong about this?” Beverly had a hopeful expression, and with good reason. While Tori had already been a thief when she was recruited by the guild, Beverly was merely someone who had unexpectedly found herself with a power she couldn’t control. Initially, working with the guild had been about getting a grip on her abilities—her only option, given that Beverly *hated* anything to do with Professor Quantum. Not without reason, either. However, such was not their concern tonight. The issue was that four capes might have just moved in down the hall from a pair of guild-member villains. That didn’t bode well, especially if Beverly was hoping to transition back into a normal life.

Tori turned the fact around in her head, but there wasn’t much wiggle room. “The sizes and general looks all match up. Austin was showing off some clearly enhanced strength, which corresponds with what we’ve seen from Agent Quantum. Plus, I recognize Kyle’s voice. Not from when he was in front of the crowd, but from when he talked to me after. Must have let his guard down and slipped into more natural tones. Wow, they are *bad* at this.”

At her own words, understanding suddenly clicked into place for Tori. A cape moving in down the hall from someone they’d saved in the same week was essentially an impossible coincidence. But the AHC forcing a cape who’d inadvertently put a civilian into harm’s way to watch over that civilian... shit, Ivan had even said they were going to make amends.

*This* was what he’d meant? How in the hells had Ivan signed off on the idea? Tori didn’t have to wonder this time; she already knew the answer.

He'd said yes because that was the answer a normal person would give. People loved the capes, especially in Ridge City, so rebuking their offer would definitely stick out in people's heads. Of course, there was also the possibility that Ivan hadn't gotten any say in the matter. They had, at best, a lightly diplomatic relationship with the Alliance of Heroic Champions. That didn't mean the guild had veto rights on whatever plans the AHC put into motion.

Much as Tori might have liked to offer false hope, this was not a situation where it was smart to keep her ally in the dark. Methodically, Tori broke down her suspicions for Beverly, who, by the end, actually *was* sporting a cheerier face.

"Okay. That's not so bad. Yeah, it sucks that they're around, but it's not because they know who we are. And I'm relieved to hear that you're their main focus. After Austin kept looking at me in the hall, I thought he was trying to figure out which masked criminal I am." As Beverly grinned, the green of her eyes brightened momentarily. No one would know her mask, largely because she only ever wore her costume around the guild. In the field, she was always transformed, and it would be quite the detective who realized Bahamut the terrifying dragon-shifter was in fact this capable young woman.

"No, I'm pretty sure that look had nothing to do with Bahamut and everything to do with Beverly." To her surprise, given their predicament, Tori felt a chuckle try to bubble up. "I mean, the guy saw you and literally dropped a couch. Doesn't get a lot more overt than that."

"Or he was trying to cover up for using his strength in public," Beverly countered.

Tori let it go, for the moment. They had bigger issues to tackle. "Assuming the guild knows about this and we're stuck with the situation, what are we going to do? If that team really is here to keep an eye on me, they'll probably try getting closer to us."

"Is telling them to 'fuck off' not an option? It tends to be your go-to move when strangers try interacting with you."

"That's for randos on the street," Tori replied. "This is trickier. If we let them into our lives a little, then that's the method they'll use for surveillance. If we tell them to eat shit, they'd still have to do their job, which would mean watching us covertly."



It was easy to see Beverly's symmetrical features and mistakenly believe beauty to be her greatest feature, but those who knew her well were keenly aware there was a sharp, dangerous mind behind those mesmerizing green eyes. "I get it. We either let them in on our own terms, or we deal with being spied on for the foreseeable future."

"Or both," Tori added. "They could just as easily do both, assuming we're even right about it all." She paused, giving her next words proper consideration. "Look, this might be about me, but I think you should get to make the call. To me, the Science Sentries are just one more team from the past, a reboot to something I never cared much about. To you, it's personal. I'm not going to ask you to grit your teeth and smile at those capes. Not in our home."

Beverly's usual confidence flickered for a moment, surprise and old pain both rising to the surface. After nearly half a minute of silence, she finally met Tori's eyes. "I might not have set out to join a guild of villains, but I still did it. I made that choice. Part of that means, for better or worse, I'm always going to be a little bit tied to the capes. My grudges can't be more important than my current life, or the relationships in it. Sooner or later, I have to learn to at least minimally deal with capes, unless I want to draw suspicion toward myself and my friends. If I can cope with Professor Quantum's new team, I'll be able to handle anyone. I won't promise it will always go well, but I'll stay as civil as possible."

A loud banging on the door reminded them that this was not a two-person apartment, no matter how deeply they got lost in discussion. "Come on, you two. Dinner is getting cold. Hold your clandestine meetings after we eat."

Both women laughed as the somber mood that had descended was quickly dispelled. Beverly rose first, a smirk lingering on her lips. "Chloe's right, let's not try to bite this off all at once. We know they're here, and we suspect why. The next move is theirs. Although, if you wanted to talk to Wade about any tech upgrades..."

"If we use a piece of Doctor Mechaniacal tech and they find out, we then have to explain how we got it," Tori interrupted.

"Right. That stuff isn't exactly commercially available. Guess we'll come up something, and by that, I mean my genius inventor roommate who brought the capes here with her will find a solution."

"But no pressure, right?" Tori asked.

“Well, a little pressure.” Beverly gave her friend a pointed look. “Or have you forgotten that we definitely need to slip away unnoticed tomorrow?”

Shit. Tori actually *had* forgotten, in all the excitement of their new neighbors. Tomorrow night, the Guild of Villainous Reformation opened the doors of its new headquarters. Not the sort of event one wanted to miss, especially when the guests were famed criminals of incredible power.

While it wouldn’t be much help in the moment, this was one more reminder that she *really* had to install some secret tunnels into this building already.



Cyber Geek was nearly to his destination when a voice from one of the AHC’s many coordinators crackled in his ear.

“Cyber Geek, your team is to halt approach immediately. We just detected a tremendous amount of energy spiking in that area. They’ve either got some sort of dangerous item or a meta who was shielding their true potential. This situation has escalated beyond your capabilities.”

The words stung, even as he turned to halt the others. Medley looked especially ferocious tonight, claws extended and fangs on full display. Cold Shoulder was already inside a moving ice-construct, putting her on equal intimidation grounds with Medley. Even Hat Trick had put on a serious face. They didn’t know much about the job, only that someone had broken into a residential building to supposedly rob a hidden vault. While there were civilians in the building, none were near the scene of the crime, so they weren’t considered to be in immediate danger. Having a meta with lots of power changed that; it put the civilians in play, so deep down, Cyber Geek knew this was the right move. The job called for someone more experienced.

Still, seeing the flickering lights coming from the ground floor, Cyber Geek’s stomach turned. In his non-masked form as Donald Moss, he’d been forced onto the sidelines for most of his life. Never brave or strong enough to make a difference. Doing it now, though, was different. It was almost more than he could bear, knowing that people were in danger.

“How long until our reinforcements arrive? The lights are getting brighter, seems to be building to something.” Cyber Geek didn’t intend to break orders, but he also wouldn’t cool his heels if civilians were in danger. That wasn’t the kind of superhero he was training to be.

“I wouldn’t exactly call her ‘reinforcements’. Count your lucky stars, rookies. Most people go years before they happen to catch her in the field.” There was a smugness to the voice that Donald didn’t have to wonder about.

From the east—states away if she was coming from Ridge City—a golden bolt tore out of the night sky. It zipped into the building and out the other side. With the golden bolt vanishing, so too did the pulsing glow. Squinting, Cyber Geek noticed a bright red flash high up in the sky, perhaps past the limits of their very atmosphere.

The crooks came running out the front of the building, slipping and falling atop one another in a desperate race for a van parked not far from the entrance. They were halfway there when the golden light returned, landing directly between the four would-be masterminds and their escape vehicle.

Around him, Cyber Geek could hear lungs go still as they unintentionally all held their breath. While they’d met her briefly during the Ridge City Riots, this was most of the team’s first time to see her on the job in person. Only a young Donald, many years before his Cyber Geek days, had caught the show once prior. It was an experience that had been locked into his mind.

One could forget many things, but a front row seat to watch Lodestar save the day was a memory that endured.

“You’re all probably panicking right now, and with good reason. Yes, your scheme is undone and you’ve been caught, so you’ll be going to jail. That said, you’ve still got a trial ahead of you, so don’t ruin your own cases by doing something stupid like—”

In that moment, Cyber Geek wondered if the criminal had shot at that precise moment on purpose, or if Lodestar had known exactly how long it would take and had timed her speech appropriately. The first was more likely, but there was something about the way Lodestar controlled the situation that left Cyber Geek slightly unsure.

The bullet, as countless had before it, struck Lodestar and bounced harmlessly to the ground. She let out a tired sigh, looking from it to the shooter. “As I was saying, don’t be stupid and try to shoot me, since—”

At that moment, all four men opened fire. Looking more disappointed than mad, Lodestar stopped each one by standing still and letting the bullets hit. When the final casing was spent, one crook, the original shooter, reared back and hurled his weapon at Lodestar's head. This one, she caught, crumpling the firearm effortlessly in her fingers.

"I guess it's nice to know some things never change. Seriously, did you expect that to work after all the bullets did nothing?"

The now-gunless gunman didn't respond. He'd turned around and began to flee, sprinting away at top speed. Whatever bravery he'd held had broken; he was now in a mad dash for freedom. The effort was understandable, but pointless. He was a hunk of driftwood trying to float away from a tidal wave.

In a literal flash, Lodestar was there. Moving almost too fast to see, she knocked her target carefully to the ground, then zip-tied his arms and legs. The others attempted to scatter as well, but in less than thirty seconds, she'd gathered them all into a neat pile.

"Situation resolved. They had some kind of hyper-advanced bomb to blow the safe. Based on how big it was, even at the edge of space, that thing would've taken out this whole building and a fair chunk of the block. Let the police know that, if at all possible, we want to know where they got it. This is the third crew with gear above their station just this week, and each one has been in a different part of the country. We need a handle on this, and soon."

Lodestar glanced over to where Cyber Geek and the others were waiting. To their surprise, she greeted the team with a warm smile and waved them over. Tentatively, all keenly aware they were approaching a living legend, they made the trek over.

"Hey there, nice to see you all again. Sorry to horn in on your scene, especially when we finally let you out of Ridge City, but this job keeps us all on our toes no matter how long we do it. Have to roll with the surprises, especially the potentially devastating ones."

Lodestar paused, taking the time to look each of them in the eyes. "You did the right thing. I know it's not easy to wait when people need you. I really do. But the powers in this world run a wide gamut, and getting killed easily by someone out of your league doesn't help anyone. Not you, not your fellow superheroes, and certainly not any civilian who might have needed you in the future. I want you to know that even if it wasn't easy, you

did well tonight. That's what makes a superhero, more than the fighting or the powers: doing the right thing, especially when it's hard."

None of them had been sure what to expect when Lodestar waved them over. Even the most optimistic hadn't imagined they'd be getting a speech praising them for following orders. The more cynical part of Cyber Geek wanted to believe her speech was formulated to condition newer recruits to do as they were told. But the truth was, he understood what she was getting at. Cyber Geek had seen Fornax return, had watched him slap around a cape as strong as Apollo. Some threats were too big for them, and no matter how their pride might buck at the idea, there would be times they had to put their trust in the stronger superheroes.

"How will we know when we're ready for more?" Medley was the one to ask it, because that was who Ren was at his core: always competitive, always striving to be better. In his human days, that tendency might have been more subdued, but since his transformation, being a superhero was his only major positive outlet. More and more of who he was had been poured into that identity, and the work that went with it. "I know we have to start small, but I also like to test myself and measure my growth. It's hard to do that when we're always working the lowest-risk jobs."

She looked at Medley, truly took him in, and nodded. "I can understand and respect that. However, I hope you can in turn see why the time to take the inherent risks of such tests should never be done in the field, when civilian lives are in play. Yes, the job will push you to and past your limits, but we do not seek those situations. That's called courting death. It is a fair request, though, so I'll think on setting something up for you. Back in the day, we used to... well, I'll talk to the Champions' Congress first."

Lodestar stepped forward, clapping them each on the shoulder in turn. "Until then, I need you four to do me a favor. Stand guard over these crooks until the police arrive. There's word of some giant meta-beast rampaging in Uruguay, so I need to get moving. Stay alert, and watch one another's backs. You're not home safe until you're home, safe."

With that, she leapt into the sky, a golden light that tore quickly out of sight.

From behind Cyber Geek, Hat Trick started to gasp for air and fell onto Medley's shoulder.

"By Houdini's handcuffs, I was so nervous I forgot to breathe."

Although his lungs had kept working, Cyber Geek understood the sentiment. Even after months at the AHC and growing accustomed to thinking of himself as a real cape, the older heroes still intimidated him. And those were just the normal ones. Being around Lodestar drove home to them all just how large the divide between some meta powers was. Merely standing in the same space as her was daunting. Perhaps that was why she was so warm, to try to undercut some of the legacy that lived on her heels.

Whatever the case, Cyber Geek was just thankful Lodestar was on their side. It was scary to admit, but if Lodestar turned evil, he wasn't entirely sure there was another meta who could stop her.

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## Chapter 11

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The car came precisely at six in the evening, whispering up to the curb with the sort of undeniable perfection Tori had begun to associate with Doctor Mechaniacal's mechanical drivers. Both women had just stepped out of the building, holding bags. For Beverly, a simple gym duffel was enough to contain the secret attire she was carting around, but Tori required something more substantial.

To even a well-trained eye, Tori merely appeared to be dragging a sizable rolling suitcase, the kind too large for even the most foolishly optimistic of travelers to attempt stowing in the overhead compartment on a plane. It was, in fact, exactly that; however, it was also a tad more. Though Tori had yet to perfectly reproduce the miniature gravitational anomaly generator that Ivan had gifted her—even the base component costs for that model were out of her reach—she *had* successfully managed to create weaker versions of it. None that would get a heavy meta-suit airborne on their own, but two built into a custom suitcase were potent enough to make it transportable.

No sooner had they exited their building than the car was there, human-appearing helper bots coming to cart away their luggage. If Wade wanted, he could have upended the entire travel industry overnight with these helpers, to say nothing of slotting them into manual labor jobs. Tori hadn't seen everything behind the curtain, but she had a hunch these inventions were what kept a massive structure like the guild functioning. She'd certainly never seen Thuggernaut or Xelas scrubbing toilets. The latter would probably blow one up if she tried.

It was one more pointless, nervous thought atop an array of them. Despite her soft spot for the guild, going back would always be a slightly scary prospect. The people she'd aligned herself with were not to be trifled with. Even trying to live under the radar, there was an inherent danger to all of them. Ivan, easily the most domesticated villain of any she'd met, had proven that point earlier this week. These people lived by their laws, not society's, but breaking them still carried consequences.

"Where do you think we're going?" Beverly was looking out the window as the streets rolled past. They were heading toward a highway junction; once there, they'd get a better idea of their destination's direction. "Can't be back downtown. No way even Wade could do that much construction without someone noticing."

"Never underestimate Doctor Mechanical's ingenuity, especially with the pockets of Wade Wyatt backing him up." While Ivan was her mentor and teacher, Doctor Mechanical was the villain Tori had grown up respecting most. He was a builder like her, who'd gone down the same path she wanted to travel: inventor, entrepreneur, a person in charge of their own destiny.

The car hit the highway junction and turned east. It rolled along past several exits, then took one much sooner than either woman was expecting. The car wound its way along a twisting side street that was surrounded by trees before finally breaking over a hill, lending Beverly and Tori their first glimpse of an exceptional view.

Huge sections of grass framed either side of the wide road, dotted by walking paths leading off to tennis courts, several structures of various sizes, and a massive pool. Directly before them was the major feature, though. A huge building that dripped with luxury dominated their field of view, so large it nearly obscured most of the visible golf course directly behind it. The architecture made it look old, yet there was not a single worn or unpolished section that Tori could spot. It was gorgeous, already twinkling with countless bulbs in the fading light of evening.

Lined up before it was a procession of vehicles, each similar to their own without being completely identical. One by one, the cars approached the front and unloaded their charges. There was a moment Tori was afraid they'd ended up at the wrong place somehow, but when she saw the distinctive form of Thuggernaut emerge next to a shorter shape that was most likely Johnny Three Dicks, there could be no question about it.



“That son of a bitch bought a country club.” Beverly already had her phone out, typing away on the bright digital keyboard. “Here we go: Astmire Country Club, founded in the early nineteen hundreds, did the usual rich people bullshit and fell out of fashion as better options came on the scene. Bunch of stories about them trying to rebrand and stage a comeback. Guess the Ridge City Riots were their breaking point; looks like they sold not long after. Don’t recognize the name of the company they were sold to: Majestic Meadows Management. Shell?”

“Has to be, right?” Tori agreed. She was scanning all over, taking in the scenery. Beautiful though it was, this all still felt off. They were much too exposed. Any cape with half a brain could coordinate a raid on this facility. The last guild had been a fortified building downtown, surrounded by civilian structures that limited the amount of force a cape could use. This place was easy pickings.

Reminding herself of her own words only a bit prior, Tori gave Doctor Mechaniacal the benefit of the doubt. He’d been running this guild since long before she joined. If this was the new base he’d chosen, then there was a good reason for that. And she wouldn’t have to wait long to find out.

The car eased to a stop, letting them off in front of the massive building. She and Beverly both hopped out, their bags already unloaded by the time they came around the back. Sharing a brief look with one another, they picked up their luggage and headed toward the door. Another helper-bot was waiting for them, this one with a smile that flirted at the edge of the Uncanny Valley.

“Welcome to the Sprawling Wyatt, a private club for only the most exclusive of members. Please, let one of our staff show you to the changing rooms. I’ll sure you’ll want to get ready before the festivities begin.”



Ivan sat, examining the room. It was a fine chamber for the Council of Villains to gather. Huge, circular wooden table, nice carpeting, comfortable chairs. This would be a good place for conferences. His fingers drummed against the smooth, polished surface of the table. The single item was probably more expensive than anything in Ivan’s home, even before it was partially destroyed. Wade didn’t skimp on the nicer things in life, especially

not where the guild was concerned. This new base was a testament to that, and the club itself was merely the surface level of that expense.

They'd already had the meeting where Ivan brought the others up to speed on his Starscout situation. The odds of it blowing back on the guild were infinitesimal, but in a world where the impossible was commonplace, only an arrogant fool left such things to chance. Now, the others knew about the situation, and could take steps to protect themselves just in case. The only part Ivan didn't divulge was how, exactly, he'd been in contact with Lodestar to get punished, along with the fact that she'd be serving alongside him. There was a difference between keeping the guild up to speed and betraying a friend's trust.

All that remained now was the revelry. Then would come the trouble. Because when the toasts were drunk and the party finished, they would go back to being a guild of villains. A guild where Ivan no longer quite knew where he fit. Before, it had been simple. He had a promise to keep, a debt to repay. Well, partially repay; some debts could never truly be made whole. But the star had fallen from the sky. He no longer had to hold the worst of the world at bay to keep its people from needing their champion.

Had this issue come up a year prior, Ivan would have easily abdicated his position on the council and taken a more removed role, coming in only when truly needed. That had been before, though: before Tori, before training an apprentice and getting more involved, before remembering why he'd help found this place.

Before seeing what happened when the guild's darker influences ran about unchecked.

He still wondered: if he'd been more involved, would he have sniffed out Balaam's plot? Maybe not—the theatrical mage hadn't made it onto the council without merit and skill of his own—yet Ivan couldn't help thinking he'd have caught *something*.

Ivan knew himself better than most. He knew he functioned best when he had an objective, a goal, something to keep him moving. Fatherhood was excellent in the long term, but that didn't fill the days, especially given his visitation schedule. He needed more, something to work toward. It was a serious matter for contemplation; however, Ivan realized that it likely wouldn't happen tonight. He'd be better served by getting out of his head and paying attention to what was going on.

Wade tended to keep a few surprises, even from his fellow councilors.



The first version of the meta-suit had been a prototype, which was the polite version of saying it was an iteration that worked despite the sizable accumulation of mistakes in its design and construction. That still put it a cut above all the prior attempts that couldn't even clear the bar of functionality, but there had been ample room for improvement.

Aside from the basic adjustments, like fine-tuning her systems and smoothing out some clunky parts in the design, Tori's first major upgrade were the entry options. Like before, her meta-suit broke apart; however, it now also had a specialized intake and expulsion system, permitting her to jump in and out using her fire form. Of course, that would only work once the suit was on and powered up; otherwise, it wouldn't stand in place while she went exploring. Between the museum fight where she was nearly captured and scrambling to put her suit on when Rust Tooth attacked Ivan's house, Tori had decided a quick way in and out was essential.

The next serious update was to the beam weapon on one of her gauntlets. This one had been tweaked, adding a cover to the lens on the palm so it wasn't capable of being targeted, while also streamlining the charge sequence. But the biggest change was that she now had the systems on both hands. This gizmo had saved her life, and was one of her only ways to deal out a lot of hurt in a short span, so it had definitely earned an expansion. Working them in alongside the fingertip torches was tough, but the upside to a closed guild meant that there had been ample time for such endeavors.

Her last major change was possibly the most effort-intensive of the bunch, but also had the biggest overall impact. Like the suitcase she'd brought it over in, her new suit had been fitted with dozens of smaller, less potent, miniature gravitational anomaly generators. Tori had noticed her suit's lack of mobility the last time she'd taken it on a real run. Because of the weight, it clanged and clanked around, not to mention moved with less grace and precision than she might have liked.

The new gravitational network wasn't meant to make the suit light enough to fly, which required far more power. Instead, this new system worked to manipulate the meta-suit's weight constantly on a lower level, allowing the user to move around with weight near equivalent to a normal person's when walking around, or to swing with the full heft of a metal fist.

The system wasn't perfect yet—there was still a seconds-long lag when switching between the weight settings—however, as Tori locked her last boot in place, she could feel a tremendous difference. Thanks to spreading it out over a network, displacing the gravity took less power than using the meta-suit's full strength to move. Given further calibration, she could probably get it even more efficient, but that would have to wait for another day.

With her suit almost fully donned, Tori examined herself in the mirror. The new metal pieces were dark, like the rest, with flashes of red light shining through. She saw no reason to break a good motif. Unlike before, there were no odd lumps or bits of wire poking out. This reworked design had a bit of polish, both literal and metaphorical. Smooth lines, efficient design, she could have marveled at her work for hours. Sadly, that would have made her late, and this was not the place for such rudeness.

Carefully, with more tenderness than the item required, Tori lifted up the final component—a new helmet, with a few minor upgrades and the same glowing red eyes. There was no reason she *had* to make her meta-suits like this. Her villain apprenticeship was over. She was free. If Tori wanted to work on meta-suits that were more market friendly, she could: make a prototype of that, get funding on her terms, start the next phase of her life. And maybe she would, when she was ready. But this wasn't just *a* meta-suit anymore. This was something more, something personal. Tori would always make the suits for this place intimidating, because if she was donning it, there was a good chance she wanted to be scary.

A small hiss from the helmet's lock as it sealed onto the torso section. For a moment, darkness, and then the screen before her grew bright. Visual systems cycled through their start-up sequence before locking into the standard viewmode. This showed what was in front of the user, along with additional information that could be toggled through as needed. No such features were required in the moment; just seeing was more than enough.

Tori had vanished. In her place stood Hephaestus, known thief and suspected connection with Fornax.

Seeing the form, part of her had been worried it would feel strange to be back in the suit... like this was a delusion from her time training, and in the cold light of reality, things would feel different. The fear had been baseless. In that moment, she felt the difference come over her. Even if she hadn't

understood it at the time, she was thankful Ivan had forced Tori to divide her identities. It was good to have a line between Tori and Hephaestus.

With the armor in place, Hephaestus opened the door to find Beverly in costume and green dragon form—which meant she was now Bahamut—along with one of the butler-bots.

“About time,” Bahamut rumbled in the rougher voice of her dragon.

“One cannot hurry perfection.” Hephaestus sounded different as well, Tori’s voice run through a minor distorter. The effect could be increased when she was talking to capes, but it defaulted to a lower setting to keep communication easy. “Besides, I don’t think we’re late.”

“Not yet, but the hour draws nigh. If you would both follow me.” The butler turned and headed down a new hallway, and the suit of mechanical black metal and the humanoid green dragon followed.

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## Chapter 12

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When they arrived at the staircase winding downward, into what had no doubt originally been a wine cellar, Hephaestus felt a hunch tickle her mind. Perhaps Doctor Mechanical hadn't left them exposed after all. If the country club up top was a simple façade, there could be any manner of facilities installed into the lower floor.

Together, she and Bahamut made their way single file down the stairs. It was big enough to accommodate even their most sizable members, albeit not by a large margin. Stepping down into a short hallway, they followed the only path forward.

There had certainly been some renovations down here, though not quite to the scale Hephaestus was imagining. Lights hummed along the walls, the air crackled with power, and Hephaestus felt more at home among the staggering amount of tech lining the walls. Most of it was no doubt designed to conceal this place's existence and protect it from outsiders; however, at least some had to be related to the enormous metal gateway at the far end of the room—a perfect arch that seemed to lead to a stone wall, energy sparking along its various spires and panels.

“If you would please be so kind as to wait, the next gate will be opening shortly.” Another helper-bot was standing by the arch. Except... this one didn't look quite right. Tori might be subpar at reading people, but she was an expert when it came to technology. This bot had a mild slump in its stance, and the hints of a mischievous twist at the edge of its mouth. On a human, minor blips, but machines didn't get to deviate and have individual quirks... except for the ones that had achieved sentience, of course.

“You can drop the hologram, Xelas.” Hephaestus was, admittedly, taking a swing. Then again, there were only so many troublemaking AIs associated with the guild, and Xelas loved to mess with people.

The image of a plain man flickered away. In his place stood a metallic woman of great renown in the scientific community. Xelas, the first artificially-created lifeform to sue for and win her freedom, might have ended up on the side of the capes if not for the circumstance of her creation. Even if that had happened, she’d have never been right for them: a guild of villains was where she belonged. And few ever looked as at home in the guild as Xelas, her artificial face capable of displaying very real emotion, when she so chose.

“Can’t blame me for seeing how you lot treat the non-sentients. Have to watch their backs.” Stepping away from the wall, Xelas motioned to the arch before them. “Anyone think they know what this is?”

Bahamut started to raise her hand, then thought better of it. “Teleporter? I mean, we saw people come in here, got led to this room, and now no one else is around. It’s either a teleporter or you’re about to kill us and use that thing to get rid of our bodies.”

Hephaestus hadn’t actually considered that, which was all the more worrying when Xelas gave an enthusiastic nod.

“Not where we’re taking things tonight, but I like your instincts. You’re sort of right in that it’s a teleporter, and sort of wrong. It’s a linked gateway. I’ll spare you the technobabble; just know that achieving true teleportation using pure tech is crazy difficult, even with the former laws of physics being turned more into guidelines. It’s been done, but the only people who could properly use those devices were the ones who invented them—that’s how complex they were. Creating a linked system between two gates, on the other hand, is way more doable. We didn’t have the technology perfected when the last guild was being constructed, however this time, our options were expanded.”

Beneath the gauntlets of Hephaestus, Tori’s fingers itched to dig into this strange system’s circuitry. It was insane how far ahead people like Wade and Professor Quantum were. If she were attempting to invent this on her own, it would have been an impossible task. Luckily, one of the upsides to being a villain was that stealing went right along with the territory. Not that she planned to copy any of their designs—just learn from them, and

then integrate that tech into her own works. A teleporting meta-suit, for example, would have tremendous possibilities.

“Sounds pretty awesome. Why the wait?” Bahamut lumbered slightly closer, giving the metal a test sniff with her scaly snout.

“This thing takes a *ton* of power to run. During normal operations, we’ll have a real helper-bot here to turn it on and off as needed. Tonight, knowing villains’ tendency to stagger in regardless of starting time, Doc left it running on ten-minute intervals. Next one is coming up soon. In fact, both of you should get ready.”

At Xelas’s words, the air around the arch grew heavy, like the wind just before a lightning storm. Sharp blue bolts ran from one side to the other, increasing in number until the whole space looked like a web built by some sort of electric spider. Without warning, the center appeared to ignite, creating a wave of rippling energy that finally stabilized into a mostly-constant wall of blue light.

With a flourish, Xelas motioned to the gateway. “Unless you want to chew the fat with me for another ten minutes, you might want to hustle on through. I’ll be over in a few more trips, so try not to start any good fights until I get there.”

Part of Hephaestus wanted to be afraid of the idea of leaping through space and time with only circuitry guiding her destination, but she was too damned excited. Besides, they’d basically done this all through her training, thanks to the meta pair known as Tunnel Vision. This was just a different—most likely riskier—form of that.

Taking Bahamut’s hand, Hephaestus and her friend stepped forward, feeling the blue light wash over them. They emerged in a very similar room with a near-identical archway at their back. Hephaestus’s navigation system attempted to identify their new location but was unable to connect with any satellites. While it stood to reason that Doctor Mechaniacal would have this place shielded, Hephaestus still grumbled as they made their way toward the staircase leading upward. This took them to another hall, then more stairs, before they finally spotted light and heard voices from up ahead.

Following the sounds, they discovered an elevated outdoor balcony. The minor grumblings from Hephaestus died out as they stepped into the light and saw, for the first time, their actual new guild headquarters.

They were probably in a different time zone, given the sunshine streaming down. Also, so far as Hephaestus was aware, Ridge City didn’t



have turquoise blue water surrounding it on all sides, or gorgeous swaths of trees running between strips of pure white sand.

An island lair. Doctor Mechanial had built some underground base; he'd fashioned his new headquarters in the middle of paradise. She could see a half dozen interconnected buildings stretching out below; in fact, the bulk of the party seemed to be happening near one of the larger structures. The strange thing was, Hephaestus couldn't see anything big enough to function as the main hub they'd used the last time. Had Doctor Mechanial merely spread out the required area? But that would be harder to defend, and after the last base fell, protection had to be of paramount concern.

Looking down, Hephaestus noticed the path from the balcony led in multiple directions. One was back toward the gateway chamber, one headed toward the party, and several others appeared to go farther up. Turning around to look behind her, Hephaestus was thankful for the helmet hiding what had to be an expression of dumbfounded shock. Her heavy hand tapped Bahamut on the shoulder, over and over until she got a reaction.

"Okay, okay, what do you need? Sorry, I was kind of scoping... this... out." Her words faded as she turned, following Hephaestus's stare.

Having emerged, they could now see the structure they'd come out of, and it was not a building as they'd initially suspected. No, they were on the lowest section of a massive, dark mound that rose into the sky, casting a shadow on the nearby stretch of beach. A dozen more entrances dotted the exterior, led to by lighted and covered pathways connected to landings like the one Hephaestus and Bahamut were standing on. There was no mistaking this structure, though. It could only be one thing.

A volcano. Doctor Mechanial had built an island *volcano* lair.

Well, it certainly fit the image of a guild of criminals, though arguably, the country club did an equally good job in that regard. If nothing else, Hephaestus wasn't going to argue with a classic. She and Bahamut headed down toward the gathering of villains, eager to see what other surprises the day had in store.



"I still think it's too brazen. An entire island? No matter how much tech you use, we can't keep it concealed forever. Besides, you know this will tweak

Professor Quantum. He's famously used an island base for decades."

Ivan, not yet clad in his Pseudonym outfit, stood in Wade's—really, Doctor Mechaniacal's—new office, overlooking the north side of the island. This was a fight they hadn't had leading up to the reveal, because Ivan had been left in the dark, probably to avoid the very reaction he was having now.

"As I'm trying to explain, I didn't steal Professor Quantum's idea," Wade shot back, refusing to yield ground as he adjusted his collar in the mirror. He didn't make an effort often, but when he did, Wade tried to show it. "I stole Tyranny's idea, which was much better."

That brought Ivan up short. There were many ways to deal with capes, and hiding behind the law was a favorite among smart crooks. It was the foundation for how the guild operated, but there were more ways to use that tactic than just theirs. Tyranny—her official title—had utilized a different method. After The Seismologist broke three major landmasses off of Australia, the smallest was considered unsalvageable. It had simply suffered too much loss of flora and fauna during the quake that tore it loose.

Until Tyranny, that was. Her technology restored the land—including insect-bots which were able to take over duties like pollination—and her offensive measures ensured that the natural predators trying to overtake the abandoned land were kept in check. She rebuilt the island by herself, then sent out a declaration to the Australian government. Tyranny would use her tech to restore the other damaged islands as well, but only if she were formally given recognized rule of the one she'd fixed. It was a simple call. They'd already written off the land as lost, and her offer would save them billions in restorative efforts.

And thus, the nation of Indroga was born. Tyranny invited anyone who wished to immigrate there with promises of stable work and housing. Meta or human, all were welcomed to the new nation. It became a trading powerhouse, producing high-end specialty goods under Tyranny's leadership. Only then did her true plan become clear, however. As a recognized ruling entity, she had complete power over the laws of her domain, and the very first one she declared was simple: no capes. Not on her island, not above her island, not in any of the space she controlled. To be a cape on Indroga was considered an act of war, with serious geopolitical consequences—especially since Indroga was a valued trading partner to so many nations. She had to play the game of politics as a tradeoff; however,

Tyranny had still managed to create an entire country free from superheroes merely by turning their own esteem for the law against them.

“You didn’t found this island,” Ivan pointed out.

“No. I bought it,” Wade agreed. “Tax, title, and license. Paid the local government a handsome sum to be officially recognized as the sole legal authority on its shores. Signed a few treaties as well; just enough so that any cape coming here uninvited technically starts about five wars. Sent a copy of all the documents to the AHC myself.”

“You told them where to find us?” After a moment’s consideration, Ivan realized Wade’s intent. “I suppose they’d figure it out soon, anyway. It’s never been the secrecy that protects our organization.”

Wade finished fiddling with his collar, having made no significant improvement. “Precisely. Not to mention that by sending the documents myself, the AHC loses any claim to ignorance. They know what they’re biting off if they come here. Won’t stop them knocking if we do something truly stupid, but they can’t come kicking in the door with some flimsy warrant this time.”

Although it still seemed like too much, Ivan trusted Wade’s judgment. He was the man helming the guild. If this was what he thought was best, then Ivan could either believe it too or try to do the job himself. That was one role Ivan never wanted to find himself even remotely near, so that meant hoping that Wade knew what he was doing.

“You should probably go change, by the way. I’ve got a Doctor Mechaniacal suit down there to give the speech in a few minutes. Wouldn’t look proper without the full council, Pseudonym.”

Wade was right. There was time for worrying when the work was done. Today, they were here for a reason. The guild had been broken by the capes. No one could deny that. Now, the rebuilding process truly began. Whether they would be weakened by the blow or grow from it depended on the individual members as much as the organization itself. But recovery started by reminding them that they were part of something bigger than themselves.

“I’ll be there shortly.” Ivan left the room, walking a short way down the hall to his own quarters. He didn’t plan to stay here outside of emergencies, but it was always nice to have a place to set his Pseudonym costume. That was all he wore, these days. Fornax was dead and buried, save for his brief resurrection last year—and, perhaps, in the itch Ivan kept noticing beneath

his skin. The desire to fight, to test himself in combat, to do what he'd been made for. He shoved those impulses down, as he had for years. There was no room for Fornax in Ivan's world. Not even this guild could contain him.

Instead, he cut a path for his room and the Pseudonym ensemble. Wade wasn't one to bluff about time, so Ivan made a point to hurry. Unsure as he was about his place within it, there was virtually no force on the planet that could have kept Ivan away from the guild's reopening ceremony.

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## Chapter 13

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The area they were in seemed more like a town square than an assembly room. At the old guild, the apprentices had only seen formal gatherings happen in the large main hall where they'd been inducted. Apparently, the new guild was going to do things differently. Cobblestone streets wound around various buildings, the paths dotted with little outposts offering different refreshments and service and staffed by the helpful bots that kept the guild operations running smoothly. Were anyone else at the guild's helm, there might have been concerns that they were overly reliant on artificial aids, but with Doctor Mechanical and Xelas as the creators, it was unlikely anyone on the planet could compromise those butler-bots.

When Hephaestus and Bahamut made their way down from the teleportation entrance, they'd spotted a half dozen familiar forms, but being in the thick of things made it harder to locate their friends. It certainly didn't help that this was the biggest guild-related crowd they'd encountered. Apprentice inductions were a special occasion, but didn't have quite the same draw as the opening of a new headquarters. Everyone who was still active within the guild was probably here, if for no other reason than to assure the others that they were, indeed, still on the guild's side. Balaam's betrayal had been stupid enough; no one wanted the organization on their heels over a misunderstanding.

Hephaestus noticed Pod Person and one of the Bytes, Meg, having frozen drinks from what seemed to be a very popular building; however, a crowd cut between them before she could call a greeting. A pair of men who were nearly identical themselves and dressed in matching costumes

almost bumped into Bahamut; both spun away with unexpected grace in the moment before collision, the slightly taller one giving a nod of apology. Hephaestus spotted Arachno Bro, a woman in an impossibly elaborate evening gown, and a creature with four wings and glowing eyes atop another building, all passing around a bottle of what looked to be incredibly expensive alcohol.

At last, a large hand clapped down on both Hephaestus and Bahamut's shoulders. They turned to find Thuggernaut staring down at them with a calm grin, along with a much less soothing smirk on his smaller accomplice's face.

"About time you two showed up. Can you believe this shit? Doctor Mechaniacal has always been a bit grandiose, but this... this is a league all its own." The unassuming man speaking went by the villainous moniker: Johnny Three Dicks. While neither Hephaestus nor Tori knew exactly what sort of meta-human he was, they knew enough about the guild itself to be sure he was dangerous, despite the gregarious, sometimes grating, personality. "If he'd put the new housing on the beach instead of inside the volcano, I might just stay here forever."

"A fact that explains *why* he didn't put the housing on the beachfront," Thuggernaut pointed out. "Although, there are a few structures near one end of the island. My guess is those will be facilities for high-earners, just like the old executive lounges." He looked away from Johnny, back to Bahamut. "Good to see you again. I wasn't sure you'd come for this."

There was no ripple of shock from those around them. Bahamut hadn't been especially enthusiastic about the crime aspect of their job, and it was common knowledge. Like many before her, she'd just wanted control of her abilities, which she'd gained largely thanks to Thuggernaut and the guild's training. With that done, she was free to become one of the guild's absentee members, making a real go of it in honest society. Those members didn't tend to show up to meetings, though this event was certainly going to be an exception to that rule for many.

"After seeing our last one torn down, there was no way I'd miss the reopening. Not to mention the chance to visit with friends." Bahamut shook her former mentor's hand.

They'd just released their grips when the sky went black. Quite literally. The sun above them died without warning, quickly replaced by a fat, shining moon and countless shining stars. A hologram of some sort,

obviously, although Hephaestus wasn't entirely sure if the sky was false, or if it had been the sunshine that was a lie. Without knowing their location, she couldn't pin down a time zone, and it was starting to look like that was intentional. This guild headquarters' location would be a secret kept even from its own members—or at least the lower-ranking ones. She assumed Ivan probably knew, if he'd cared enough to bother asking.

All around, the island started to glow as countless gentle lights sparked on. They filled the streets, winding back up the path to the volcano lair and continuing onward, bright red glows appearing on the boiling mountain to their rear. The whole island looked like a sea of light, and in any other context, Hephaestus would have taken to the sky for a bird's-eye view. Tonight, she stayed rooted. This wasn't the time to go gallivanting off. Someone wanted their attention, and there was only one real candidate who would take to using these methods.

They came from nowhere, seeming to slip out from behind buildings where they couldn't have been hiding. Seven figures, all distinctive, winding their way to the center of the cobblestone square, where Hephaestus noticed the ground was beginning to rise. One by one they came, costumed and somber, climbing the still-forming stairs onto the rising platform.

Morgana was first. Normally a kind-eyed woman with raven-black hair, when she was dressed in her full apparel as Morgana Le Faye, the Blood Witch, it was easy to see why small armies had surrendered rather than face her wrath. Merely witnessing her carnage on a battlefield was enough to remind any outsider why the guild was not to be trifled with. Born with the power to manipulate the blood of all but the most powerful beings, Morgana's department looked after all of those who had their abilities at birth.

Not far behind her was the unassuming young woman known as Stasis. Hephaestus didn't know much about her, only that she had a history with Nexus and appeared to be truly invulnerable. Plenty of meta-humans were tougher than normal; however, Stasis was something else. It was like attacks never even reached her. Given that she was the council member who oversaw those that had been turned into meta-humans by external forces—such as lab accidents—Hephaestus had managed to put a rough guess about her origins together.

Arcanicus was next, taking the stairs noticeably more slowly than the previous councilors. In his defense, he was one of the few older members of the guild who actually wore his age, and he was adorned in robes that required careful lifting. While he was a pleasant fellow who'd pitched in with their training, Hephaestus couldn't help thinking that he'd have to find a replacement for his council seat soon. Arcanicus oversaw the guild members who'd gained abilities through magic, because his predecessor, Balaam, had led an insurrection against the entire guild. He was a substitute, and an effective one, but it was clearly a temporary fix.

Gork came next. She was impossible to miss. Huge, with gray, rock-like skin, Gork was a member of a subterranean race, an explorer who'd had become trapped on the surface. She was the quietest of the council, and as consequence, her words carried more weight when finally spoken. As the member who looked over all naturally occurring non-human and alien members, Gork took her role seriously. Even if she spoke rarely, one could be sure Gork was always paying attention, watching closely, just in case.

Only a few steps from Gork was her closest friend, Xelas. The two made an odd pairing, yet apparently, it worked. They'd been serving on the council together for some time. Xelas represented all artificially created beings, be they mechanical or biological. She was also blowing kisses to the silent crowd, drumming up a few nervous titters and chuckles.

Those died out when Pseudonym stepped onto the platform. The costume was aggressively simple, just like the name, but no amount of bland would make those watching forget the power of the man before them. Whatever name Ivan used, he was a force of nature, raw destruction held in check only by a single man's relentless self-control. He had to exert such restraint; there was no other choice. The smallest of slips could have serious consequences, as Ivan himself had proven earlier that week. Pseudonym walked calmly to the middle of the stage, taking his position.

It was no coincidence that Pseudonym was next-to-last. He was there to cool the crowd, to silence them for the final arrival. This member didn't climb the stairs. Instead, he soared up from the ground, landing on the platform in a swift flash of thrusters. There was no mistaking this one. The councilor who represented all those who gained their abilities through the wielding of technology: one of the guild's original founders, and its current leader.

Doctor Mechaniacal had arrived.



“I confess, when our guild first fell, I was worried.” His voice came from all around them. Despite seeming like an outdoor square, it was becoming more and more apparent that this whole area was designed specifically for guild gatherings, to the point where speakers had apparently been woven into the streets and buildings.

While Pseudonym’s appearance had forced the crowd to go silent, Doctor Mechanial’s words caused them to grow still. No one fidgeted or moved. All focus, all attention, belonged to the head of their guild. And he knew it.

“As an inventor, I know too well that creating something is not the end of the process. There must also be testing. The world’s greatest watch that malfunctions after a drop of rain is, in truth, a terrible accessory. Testing, finding an experiment’s limits and working to break through them, is how you create something undeniably remarkable. This guild was forged out of necessity, and it has grown to best fit our goals and requirements. But until several months ago, we had yet to be truly tested.”

Doctor Mechanial paused. Memories were bubbling up, some firsthand, some of video screens they’d watched: the guild, under assault from the AHC. Fighting the capes, and then Balaam’s troops. Not everyone had made it through when the dust had settled, but as a guild, they’d endured.

“Balaam’s betrayal broke the code and the bonds of trust essential for this guild to function, but he also exposed a great many vulnerabilities in our prior systems. We have been tested, my brethren, and we have come out the other side stronger for it. There are a great many challenges facing us. The world now knows we exist, which will make working carefully all the more important. The Alliance of Heroic Champions must deal with us publicly now, and what form that will take has yet to be seen.”

Hephaestus clocked several people in the crowd getting nervous at the mere mention of the AHC. Tough as this guild was, their opponents had quite a roster of powerful personnel as well.

“But with those challenges, there is also opportunity. Living in the open allows us to play a more aggressive game, with bolder strategies. This island is one such example, and there will be more in the weeks to come. As operations resume and we begin our work anew, keep in mind what I said about testing and improvement. Because you do not test a new creation only once. You test it over and over again, until it can no longer meet the

challenge or it has become perfected. We will face more trials. Whether or not we come out the other side depends on our strength, our wits, our determination. And it is for those reasons that I am worried no longer.”

Another pause, but this one wasn’t to open old wounds. The setup had been deliberate, stoking their egos. If he weren’t a genius and a billionaire, Wade Wyatt would probably have had great career prospects as a public speaker.

“To be a villain is to live outside the law, trusting in your own power above all else. Before me, I see the faces of so many who have made that choice, and then proved they had the mettle to withstand it. We are not a gang. We are not a syndicate. We are not a mafia. We are not any of the countless human institutions the capes have trampled over through the decades. Each and every one of you is a threat, a danger, on a level great enough that even the AHC is forced to acknowledge you. There are no disposable foot soldiers in this organization: only the sorts of people capes dread meeting in the core of their souls. Because you are strong enough to strike hard, smart enough to strike well, and wise enough to strike unseen. You are danger. You are deadly. You are *villains*.”

Something like a murmur, yet closer to a hiss, rose from the crowd. There was a wicked gleam in many eyes and eye-like organs. He’d touched right on the core of their pride, the difference between themselves and the common rabble. Hephaestus could feel the sense of shared unity, even as a new member. She could only imagine how well this resonated with the older metas.

“You are villains,” Doctor Mechanial repeated. “Together, we are more than that. We are the sorts of criminals who stay free and alive to enjoy the spoils of our enterprises. We can walk down the street as ordinary people, or slip on a mask and become rulers in the shadows. We have created a new way to exist, and it has endured its first true testing to emerge greater, stronger than before.”

The metal suit stepped heavily to the center of the stage, effortlessly silencing the crowd once more as Doctor Mechanial surveyed the entire mass of people. It seemed like he somehow made time to look everyone in the eye, even if only for a split second.

“It is with great pride, honor, and humility, that I officially reopen the Guild of Villainous Reformation!”

He thrust a metal fist in the air, and on cue, the crowd began to cheer. Were Hephaestus not positioned near one of the hidden speakers, she might have missed the last two words that followed the declaration amidst the chorus of voices. Luckily, the words reached her ears, and she smiled inside her helmet, where no one could see.

“Welcome home.”

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## Chapter 14

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“I am not saying Apollo was right. I am merely stating that allowing them to reform as an organization is a mistake. We should put an end to it tonight, especially now that the public knows not every deceased villain really went in the ground.” Professor Quantum was standing, looking out one of the windows of the Champions’ Congress’ meeting room. Before him was Ridge City, twinkling in the evening light.

His thoughts were not on the city itself, however. They were directed toward a country club on the edge of town, where dozens of criminal meta-humans were gathering to toast and celebrate themselves silly. He went on, “It is a tweak of the AHC’s nose every time they meet, let alone pull some secret job while we’re busy keeping the world safe.”

“What’s your solution?” Lodestar tapped a single finger on the desk, strong enough to create a *thud* largely muffled by the floor’s carpet. “I drop down—which is trespassing, since we have neither warrants, invitations, nor do we believe the area to be in imminent danger. Maybe I lay down some threats and smack a few people around? Because now you can add harassment and assault to that list.”

“No judge would believe some common crook over—”

“First of all, if I did all those things, I’d most certainly own up to them in court,” Lodestar interrupted, killing that line of thinking in its tracks. “Secondly, even if one of our people with less integrity were to take on the role, the guild will have recordings, testimony, and a team of high-priced lawyers to frame it just right. Not to mention that after what Apollo pulled, they’ve got legal ammo to question the integrity of any investigation we

pull that isn't airtight. All of which is still dancing around the real issue: what do you want me to charge them with if we do go over and arrest everyone? All their old crimes are expunged, and unless you've been sitting on a treasure trove of evidence we don't know about, I don't have any new warrants to hand out. Quorum, you got any?"

While he largely tried to stay out of his colleagues' more passionate discussions, on this point, Quorum took the time to shake his head. Though a great many members of the AHC were uncomfortable knowing a cabal of villains was lurking around out there, ultimately, there was nothing to be done. Within the confines of the law, the AHC couldn't go after them, and if they did, it would mean becoming criminals themselves. Perhaps, under different leadership, there could have been some talk of off-the-books operations, but not with Lodestar at the helm. By her own admission, Lodestar didn't consider herself a servant of the law; however, she did respect it, and she set that standard for all the countless capes who admired her.

"There are no secret evidence stashes on our end," Lodestar concluded. "Look, Professor Quantum. I recognize that you're agitated, but rather than discuss a guild that may or may not cause trouble down the line, why don't we deal with the recent spike in street-level crime? Or maybe talk about how these random punks are turning up with extremely high-tech gear? Just this week there's been a bomb, a robber with jet boots, and some fellow swinging around an energy-axe that cut through stone."

Thankfully, this was intriguing enough to draw Professor Quantum's attention away from the guild—momentarily, if not for the evening as a whole. "Analysis of what you've brought in has yielded little. The devices lack Doctor Mechanical's signature polish. He would never tarnish his brand by selling lower quality goods on any market. Of course, I haven't been making them, so we can rule me out, too. In terms of the world's major meta-minds, that leaves only Tyranny. Given that she runs a nation, this seems like rather small potatoes for her to bother with, and none of the tech lines up with her usual creations. Therefore, the good news is that none of the three smartest inventors in the world are likely behind this. The bad news is that our culprit isn't as far behind us as I might like."

That statement caught both Lodestar and Quorum by surprise. It wasn't quite right to say that Professor Quantum had an ego. The situation was more that he was truly brilliant and knew it. He had an accurate grasp of

where his intellect ranked against the whole of humanity. The unexpected inverse of that, however, was that Professor Quantum was also willing to recognize the few others who could approach his level. If he suspected this new creator to even be in the same league as the three inventors he'd just listed, then this was a very serious issue indeed.

“What we’ve seen have largely been basic, easy-to-find components, which renders them all but untraceable. In spite of their simplicity, every device has functioned perfectly, and from looking over the remains, some appear to have been constructed in some haste. For a person to turn everyday junk into this kind of technology requires an exceptional aptitude. Worse, I do not expect we have yet seen the true extent of their talents.”

Lodestar kept listening, only now, it was *her* gaze that was darting to the window while she thought about a country club at the edge of the city. As a rule, and a philosophy, Lodestar liked to give people a chance. She believed there was good in almost everyone, that sometimes, all a person needed was the opportunity to prove it. But she'd also been doing this job for decades and had learned the dangers in ignoring a threat early on. What Professor Quantum was describing sure did seem to line up with what she'd learned about Ivan's apprentice: able to turn junk into usable tech, someone they hadn't already dealt with, hungry for income. Though surely someone with guild training would be too smart to try and open an underground black market in Ridge City, of all places.

Still, she'd have to dig a little deeper into the mystery of Tori Rivas, just to be certain. Innocent civilians were at risk and counting on her. Lodestar couldn't sit around, waiting for the criminals to reveal themselves. She needed to be out there, working to keep these people safe. After so many years away, it was the very least she owed them.



No one partied quite like villains. When Doctor Mechanical's speech ended, the stars began to change colors, turning into a slowly shifting rainbow as music replaced the leader's voice. People rushed the various food and drink vendors, and with that, all semblance of control faded away. Yelling, drinking, carousing—and that was before powers got involved. Magical creatures were summoned, inspiring unicorn races along the beach,

around which Johnny Three Dicks had a betting pool in moments. Not far from where the trees began in earnest, a giant ice cream sundae, easily the size of a house, suddenly appeared. A surprising number of people dove right into it like an emulsified pool, climbing their way up the frosty treat. When an impromptu parade began to form, Hephaestus decided to take her leave.

She slipped away, not bothering to grab Bahamut, who was biting into a keg along with Arachno Bro in some sort of super-jaw/mandible version of a keg stand. Making her way back toward the volcano, she almost stopped to greet Xelas, who was chatting up a figure in dark purple robes, but stopped when she realized the mechanical woman appeared to be excitedly going on about the latest Captain Bullshit piece. Art, especially absurdist performance art, wasn't a topic she felt like tackling tonight, so Hephaestus took a sharp turn at the last minute and continued her walk in solitude.

That's what she thought, anyway. Not long after beginning her ascent, a familiar form stepped up to her side. Maybe he'd teleported; maybe he'd been following her for a full hour while she'd taken in the festivities. With someone as powerful as Ivan, even in his aggressively bland Pseudonym costume, there were just too many options.

"Since you're calling it an early night, as expected, I wanted to see if you'd like to have a meeting."

"Depends. Is this Vendallia business, guild business, or personal?" The response might not actually change her answer, but it would change how Hephaestus approached the meeting in general.

Pseudonym took a few steps to answer, lightly tapping his chin as they walked. "All of them, I suppose. The topic is your future, so it's not really my place to say which area of your life would be most impacted."

"My future? Do I need to start on some kind of villain thesis or something? Because honestly, just kill me now. There's a reason I didn't stick it out in academia."

The quip got her a laugh, albeit a small one. From someone like Pseudonym, that basically counted as a guffaw. He shook his head, then pointed toward a different path that branched off from the one to the teleporter. "Does this seem like the kind of group that copes well with paperwork? Come on. I'll show you up to the lodging and office area. Never know when you'll need a place to hide out."

It could have been her imagination, but there seemed to be a touch of glibness in Pseudonym's voice. Was he actually in a good mood? Well, why not? When Hephaestus thought about it, they should all be in good moods. The guild was reborn, grander than ever before. That might make the future more complicated, yet for tonight, it was cause to celebrate.

They began to climb the path leading higher, though it kept a gentle slope to ensure easy walking. Although flying would have been easier, there was no rush. Especially once Pseudonym began speaking.

"Earlier this week, you saw the reason I'm a villain." He paused, reaching up to pull off his mask, his face shaded now by only the night's shadows. Ivan looked at her hard, trying to meet her eyes through the helmet. After a moment, Hephaestus hit the eject button. Her whole body turned to living flame, bursting out of the suit in a blaze before reforming. She was still wearing a costume—the mask and outfit she donned under the meta-suit in case she was ever forced out—but outside the armor, costumed or not, she was Tori in her heart. Hephaestus was a coupling of creator and invention: in Tori's esteem, anything less didn't deserve the name.

"I fight who I want, when I want. You can break my crimes down into a thousand different motivations and categories, but at the end of the day, that's the part of me that will never fit into polite society. There are plenty of reasons I am this way, yet none of them matter. I am, and so I've had to build a life around that fact."

Ivan lifted a finger, pointing back toward the party. "Doctor Mechaniacal doesn't respect laws. He views them as rules made by the powerful, and feels no obligation to obey the wishes of the tyrannical dead. Morgana will do quite literally unspeakable things to protect those she loves. Arcanicus values knowledge over everything, even if that means research into forbidden subjects or pilfering from someone else's library. Everyone here is in this guild for a reason. I wanted you to start thinking about what yours is. Not why you joined the guild, mind you—that was survival, and we both know it. No, I want you to ponder what it is that makes you a villain. Find the core of you that will not mesh with mundane society and call it by name."

A lot of things rose to mind. Her lack of trust for traditional systems and organizations, her disregard for many laws, the smoldering anger that lived where memories of her parents should have dwelled—any of them could be



called out. Tori didn't offer up an immediate answer, however. This seemed more like the kind of task that was supposed to take some time.

"Doesn't sound like an impossible task, though I do have to ask: why?" Tori could still hear the yelling and cheers rising from the crowd. "I'm here. I am a villain. I passed the tests and made my choices. What's the significance of knowing the reason?"

"There are many purposes to knowing one's self," Ivan replied. "Being aware of what lines you can't cross permits you to better focus on the ones you can. It helps to build the authenticity of your civilian persona. Of course, there's also the obvious benefit that a weakness or habit you're aware of is that much harder for an enemy to take advantage of. But the main reason I want you to figure this out is a simple one."

To her surprise, Ivan didn't look down at the partying villains. Instead, his gaze turned skyward, to the colorful false stars. "When you know the kind of villain you are, you find a starting place to decide what kind of villain you want to be. We have the kind of freedom few people dare to even dream of, Tori. We can ignore most limitations, rules, laws, what have you. Think of how many restrictions the average human operates under—restrictions of society, wealth, their own bodies. What do you have to keep you in check?"

"The code." Tori knew it well. The guild's code was how they managed to stay out of the AHC's reach. To break it was to go against the entire guild, and to her knowledge, no one had survived those odds thus far. Now, though, thinking about it in light of Ivan's words, Tori realized how truly minimal a document it really was compared to the entire tapestry of society's limitations.

"The code," Ivan repeated. "Even living within it, you can take what you want, be what you want, live how you want. With your smarts and guild connections, it won't take long before the minor, mundane hurdles you do have fall away. When that happens, when you truly see the endless opportunities stretched out before you, it helps to have some idea of how you want to use that freedom."

"Um, duh. I want to start a tech company." Tori shot Ivan a sideways glance; he already knew that damn well.

A short stare from Ivan was the initial reply before words finally followed. "You misunderstand. That's Tori's dream, the sort of career she wants." Walking over to the meta-suit, still powered up and waiting for her

return, he laid a single hand down carefully on its shoulder, feeling the metal cool in the night air.

“I was asking about Hephaestus. Her future. Her goals. Her desires. I know Tori Rivas. Hephaestus is still new. Who she is, what kind of villain she is... those are things you have to decide.”

Ivan walked over to Tori, carefully turning her to look with him out over the ocean. Wherever they were, it had one hell of a view. The sea appeared to stretch on in all directions. Constant, endless, a reminder of how small humans, and meta-humans, were in the greater scheme of the universe.

“Think of the water as opportunity. Most people live in a puddle. The capes have a journey that’s simpler, and also more limited. They’re on a river, a one-way road driving them toward the same goals. Get powers, fight crime—there’s a straightforward path to walk, so long as you don’t deviate. Villains are different. *This* is what we get. This is our prize for living outside the boundaries of societies. So many places one could go. So many horizons to chase. But if you sailed without direction, you could easily end up spending your whole life going around in a pointless circle.”

It was heavy-handed, even for Ivan, yet it got the point across. She wasn’t an apprentice anymore. Tori was a villain, in title if not reputation. Maybe it was time to start giving serious thought to exactly what that meant for her future.

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## Chapter 15

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“Was anyone else expecting this place to be warmer?” Kyle finished stripping off the last of his Tachyonic costume, stowing it away carefully and setting the most important components in their charging cradles. Of the team, only Tachyonic needed artificial enhancement to perform at acceptable levels in the field, and while it was a constant source of annoyance and shame, he still had a duty to ensure the equipment was properly prepared. After starting off the week getting lightly scolded by Lodestar, he wasn’t going to make any other rookie mistakes.

Despite moving out to an apartment, the team still retained their on-site residence at the AHC. It was policy to provide such space to all members in case anyone ever needed a place to safely rest. The quarters of the New Science Sentries were slightly nicer than most, with four individual rooms connecting to a shared common area with a small kitchenette. Dotting the walls were various charging, training, and general maintenance stations for both the team and their gear. Thankfully, no one tried to make them haul all their equipment over to the apartment for the duration of the temporary guard job. They did all have to keep spare costumes on hand there, just in case.

“We’re near the end of summer. It’s going to be cool everywhere soon. I bet even back on Vomisa, you can feel a chill in the breeze as it comes off the ocean.” Ellie emerged from her room clad in mundane attire: a cropped pink shirt and white skirt. She’d been enjoying the freedom of real fashion options since they arrived and didn’t appear to be slowing down anytime soon.

“Not the weather. The people. It’s just...” Kyle trailed off, trying to put a point to his words.

Someone else turned out to be faster on the draw.

Clad in a t-shirt proclaiming himself to be a Keg Inspector, Ike came over from the kitchen with a hand pressed to his forehead in a mock swoon. “What Kyle’s trying to say is how dare these petty mainland trash people not fall upon themselves praising our greatness?! We are the New Science Sentries, the continuation of a legacy from the dawn of superheroes, yet we haven’t seen screaming crowds, raving fans, or even a single line of groupies offering blowjobs. I, too, am outraged, *outraged* by these proceedings!”

Usually, they tried to ignore Ike, especially when he got like this, but today, he happened to hit the right nerve. “I don’t expect screaming crowds,” Kyle protested. “It’s just like no one cares. Our first day got spoiled because I messed up and put a civilian in the limelight, sure. But that was one mistake. Since then, coverage is already dying off and we’re barely getting a reaction in the streets. We’re old news that fast?”

To illustrate the point, Kyle flipped to a local television station dedicated to meta-stories, especially ones involving the AHC. There was an endless appetite for the exploits of capes, even more so now that Lodestar stories were again in the mix. Today she was not the focus, however. Instead, the camera was on some different AHC members. Apparently, the team had foiled a gang of criminals trying to rob a traveling circus, but not before some of the entertainers had been injured.

The cameras panned in to show inside the big tent, where one of the capes was doing magic tricks for a growing crowd, another was on the tightropes using some sort of strange glove apparatus that glowed slightly, and the final two were putting on a mock lion show, one holding a chair made out of ice, using it to hold back the only member Kyle recognized on sight: Medley. There were a lot of people in the AHC, but the guy who looked like someone put a zoo and steroids into a blender still stuck out.

“Is this really a good example? It’s clearly a human-interest piece, not a reflection on their skills as superheroes,” Ellie pointed out.

“Maybe so, but people love it. I’ve seen this team do street patrols, and the community turns out to greet them. Last night, we had patrols, and I swear I saw people locking their doors.” Kyle flipped the TV to mute, but continued to let the footage play. “I suppose, if our options are to not be

appreciated or to lower ourselves to these kinds of stunts, we picked the right course. I just... expected more from this town.”

The sound of heavy steps approaching could only mean one thing: Austin had finished his shower. Given that he’d gotten coated in debris and oil from lifting cars, the man had earned one. As he stepped into the lounge, he was still drying that shaggy blond hair. It didn’t fit his brand or his image, yet Austin held strong to his hairstyle. Given how much ground he’d yielded through the years, it made it stand out all the more—to the people who knew him well, at least.

Austin finished toweling off, walked to the fridge, and cracked open a bottle of water before he finally spoke. “We got here a week ago, Kyle. I know our name carries weight, but this is the heart of superhero activity. This is where the Alliance of Heroic Champions has had a base since it was founded, and it was home to the League of Metas before that. We’re trying to play country music in Nashville. Prestigious rep or not, no one is going to care until we prove ourselves.”

“Excuse me?” Kyle whirled from the television to face his friend, who seemed unbothered by the spin. “I’ve been running the numbers. Since arriving, our patrols have been among the most efficient. We’ve stopped more small-scale crimes than nearly any other local field team *and* managed a zero percent civilian injury ratio. We are killing it at this job, just like we trained for. Give us a few more weeks to learn the ropes, and we’ll blow everyone else out of the water.”

With a powerful chug, Austin slammed the entirety of his water, then tossed the bottle into a recycling bin. Moving steadily, he walked over and turned Kyle back toward the screen, where Hat Trick was pulling an endless candy scarf from her sleeve, letting it land into the waiting hands of eager children.

“There’s more to being a superhero than punching criminals and stopping bullets. You win hearts by being a person, not a mask. Perhaps next time we patrol, let’s go a little less efficiently and actually talk to the locals.”

“Speaking of the locals, do we need to work on ingratiating ourselves to the new neighbors?” Ellie asked. “It’s Saturday morning, so this is a prime time to jump on their weekend before they lock down plans.”

Kyle would have muttered about it being a huge waste of time, except that he was the reason they had to waste that time in the first place. His

mistake had landed them the job of guarding Tori, so he certainly didn't have room to complain about the tasks such a gig demanded. "I guess I could invite her over for dinner tonight. That should be a good 'getting to know you' activity."

Ellie exchanged a nervous look with Ike, who merely offered a shrug in reply. "Good god, Kyle, *I* know you grew up on a super-scientist's lab island, but let's try to hide that from new people for at least a day. Are you trying to hook up with this woman?"

A jolt of shock hit Kyle's face, twisting it into a downright comical expression. "Am I *what*?"

"That's what I thought." Ellie pushed some of her own golden locks to the side, tucking them behind her ear. "Okay, so, Kyle, if you go knock on the door of a woman you just met and ask her to dinner at your place, there are some very major social implications that go with all that. Better idea: I'll do the inviting. It will be for something neutral, like cards or board games, and we'll ask their entire apartment. Nice, non-romantic, new neighbors reaching out socially. Keeps us close to them, just not too close."

A soft clatter reached their ears. Everyone turned to notice that Austin had knocked over a stack of dishes built up in the sink. His cheeks and ears were both red with embarrassment. "You said the whole apartment? Is that wise? We should probably limit our exposure as much as possible."

"Except if we single out just Tori, the best-case conclusion they'll reach is that one of us is courting her, and if she's not receptive to the idea, then that kills the whole buddy-buddy schtick dead in the street." Ike vanished and appeared next to Austin as he spoke, not dropping so much as a syllable. "Trust Ellie. Group invite is definitely the way to go."

The debate might have continued longer, had Ike not invoked the word "trust" in his delivery. As a new leader of a new team, Austin had proven himself determined to show faith in the people he led. No sooner had the word been spoken than Austin's red flush began to fade. He turned to Ellie.

"If you think that's best, then go ahead. We should get back to our new apartment within the hour. That'll be the perfect time to extend a friendly evening invitation."

"As long as they weren't up late doing anything crazy," Ike said, the only one laughing at his joke, as usual. Based on the files they'd read, the odds of that were abysmal. The barista, the blogger, and the cubical cog—

by Ike's reckoning, they might very well be babysitting the most boring collection of people in the entire city.



After a night of revelry and excitement, Tori was grateful for the weekend. True, she'd been off work all week, but she hadn't needed a morning to sleep in until today. A few minutes in fire form nipped her hangover in the bud before it had fully formed; her ability to heal while existing as fire could quite possibly be the aspect of her power she liked the best. After a lazy shower, Tori dressed in an old shirt and overalls, readying herself for a day in the lab. Taking the meta-suit out had revealed a few more areas for tweaks and improvements. Streamline here, improve efficiency there; it was all a matter of refining the invention one step at a time.

Tori emerged to find she was the last riser of the day. Chloe was at the stove, working on her lunchtime specialty: grilled cheese. A pot of coffee was thankfully already made, so Tori poured a tall mug, pausing as she stirred in creamer to notice that Beverly was staring daggers at her. Tori took a few sips to brace herself for whatever this was about, and then traipsed over to the table.

"You look like you just ate a live chicken. What's going on?"

"Don't mind Beverly. She's just in a huff," Chloe explained. "Want a sandwich?"

After another sip of coffee, Tori nodded. "Sure. Could use some breakfast."

"Closer to lunch, lazybones. Anyway, Beverly's annoyed because while you were both snoozing, one of our new neighbors came by and invited us over for games at their place tonight. I told her I was pretty sure we were all free, but I'd check with you both to make sure. Not sure why she's feeling snitty about it when I left you both a perfectly serviceable out."

Slowly, Tori lowered her cup, meeting Beverly's intense stare. Crap. This had come way sooner than they were prepared for. And it *had* to be Chloe who answered the door. Sweet, amiable Chloe, who would obviously accept a social invitation at face value. Why not? It wasn't as if she knew who the new neighbors really were. Thinking fast, Tori catalogued their options. They could have Chloe go solo, but that felt wrong. This was Tori's

mess; she shouldn't let Chloe get unknowingly tangled up with capes, especially considering how unique Chloe's ability was. No way the capes wouldn't try to woo her to their team.

The next option was to tell Chloe everything and have her make an excuse to not go. Viable, maybe even prudent. But Chloe wasn't much at subterfuge, and the neighbors would notice when her attitude toward them dramatically shifted. That invited the asking of questions, which Tori and Beverly dearly wanted to avoid. Which only left them with one viable choice: attend the game night. Perhaps they could show themselves to be anti-social and avoid a repeat invitation. While that was an admittedly easier task for Tori than Beverly, they'd have to think of something. She barely had any free time as it was. Forging a fake friendship with a bunch of capes was not a project Tori wanted to take on.

"You know Beverly, she hates the idea of being rude. I bet she's worried she'll get way too competitive playing games with the new people." Tori shot Beverly a conspiratorial wink, which earned her a heavy glare. "She never misses an event, though, so you can count us both in."

"Or I'm just up after a long night and I've got you both haranguing me. I'm sure I'll find my party spirit after a shower and a little time to knock the sleep from my eyes." Beverly's expression melted back to friendliness for Chloe just as she dropped a steaming sandwich onto Beverly's plate.

Thus far, Chloe had burned a roast, spaghetti, and somehow a salad during her cooking rotations. They'd learned that she did best with stuff that just went into an oven on a timer and making grilled cheese. To her credit, bad as she was at most culinary endeavors, the woman grilled a mean cheese.

"Much better attitude," Chloe complimented. "It'll be good for us all. I know we've had a lot going on; a little social engagement is just what we need to unwind. They want us over at six, and we should bring a bottle of wine. It's polite."

For a moment, Tori had flashbacks to living under Ivan's roof, but they cleared away at her first bite. Even on her best dish, Chloe was no Ivan. One day, Tori would have to find out exactly why it was that one of the world's most terrifying monsters was also a shockingly capable cook.

Actually, now that she thought about it, Ivan still owed her an origin story. It had fallen to the back of her mind in the chaos surrounding the end of her apprenticeship, but that was a deal she definitely needed to collect



on. Another day, though. One where she didn't have to figure out how to have a social night with a group of capes less than a day after toasting to the resurrection of a guild of villains.

Swallowing her bite of sandwich harder than necessary, Tori realized that somewhere along the way, her life had gotten incredibly complicated.

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## Chapter 16

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Their truck navigated the rocky coast inch by inch, working around the tough terrain until finally reaching a section of flat road. Here, a turn awaited them, a break in the craggy rocks running along the shore. Angling the vehicle just so, they gassed it, pushing up the steep incline. Scraping hit their ears—the passage was so narrow it was tearing off their side-view windows—but they were making progress. The sun faded from view as they vanished into the rocks, their tire tracks the only proof they'd been there at all. Tracks that would soon be washed away by the coming tide.

Inside, the cave was dark. Darker than it should have been, with a pair of headlights set on the high beams. The shadows were borderline aggressive, leaping in the moment that light wasn't directly on them. No external sounds reached their ears—even the nearby lapping of waves was gone. Just when the first member was on the verge of breaking, the lights struck a figure: tall, lean, sporting a stern expression the truck's driver associated with principals and headmasters.

Immaculately dressed in a suit nearly as black as the cave, he gave them a toothy smile as they jerked to a sudden halt, stopping mere feet from hitting the stranger. He appeared unconcerned by either them or the truck, pulling out a silver pocket watch to examine the time.

“On the dot. I must say, I'm impressed. When I have occasion to allow a delivery, they are almost always confused by the directions. You are the first ones to arrive precisely at the appointed hour. What good fortune you have. Let us see if your streak can continue. Show me the merchandise.”

Despite him being outside the vehicle, no one had difficulty hearing his voice. It was crisp, clear, and precise, like everything about this odd fellow.

Without delay, they sprang into action. Adrenaline was pumping through veins as though they were under the watchful eye of a firing squad. No, that would have been better. At least in that situation they'd know the threat. Working in a cave that seemed empty, yet didn't feel that way, was far more terrifying. No gun could live up to the terrors their own minds imagined.

Moving briskly, they unloaded the large box from the rear of the truck and popped the lid. Their driver stepped forward, clearing her throat to knock the sliver of fear from her voice. "As requested. A Cernovian intergalactic communications array."

The buyer was there, looking over their shoulders, an unsettling glee radiating off him. "Did you have trouble procuring it?"

"Some. There aren't many of these, so they're collectible, but no one besides Professor Quantum ever managed to get one working. If they were functional, they'd be much better guarded. As is, rich people use them as display pieces. We can get you more, with notice." Scary as the cave was, business was business. Besides, if he needed them alive for more jobs, it increased their odds of escaping this cave while still breathing.

At the name "Professor Quantum," the buyer's face tightened, only for a flash. "Is that so? I may well take you up on that. Won't be sure until I can take this apart and see if it needs repairs or replacement parts."

He leaned down, easily hefting the box it had taken all of the driver's more muscular staff to lift. "Your money is already in the truck. If I need your service again, I'll reach out."

A collective sigh left the team as they headed back toward the cab of the truck. Just before she arrived, the driver glanced around once, then turned back to find herself inches away from the tall buyer.

"An afternote. Do not think yourself safe beyond these walls. Speak to no one of this place, or of me. Ever. And should I require another delivery, I encourage you to continue your streak of punctuality. I am far less hospitable with those who waste my time."

They drove out of the cave so fast that the truck sustained a three-foot scratch on the left side as it scraped along the narrow passage. No one said a word of complaint. They'd have jammed the gas to fly into traffic rather than return to that cave.

Unless the money was good enough, of course.



Tori had never been much for social niceties. She hadn't received enough invitations to know what one brought to a board game night, let alone a board game night where four of the members thought they were secretly watching over a civilian, who knew they were actually superheroes and was in fact herself a villain, as was a fellow attendee. That made Chloe, the barista trying to keep her power a secret, the most normal of the entire bunch. If she were more personable, Tori would have resolved to start making less complicated friends. Sadly, even in a world with magic and aliens, some things were still impossible.

In the end, it was Beverly who took charge. She chose a bottle of wine, picked up a cheap card game about building the ideal sandwich, and directed everyone to dress like they were going out to a bar. After Tori emerged still clad in her overalls, Beverly marched her into the bedroom and picked out a better outfit. Granted, this ensemble was still a t-shirt and jeans, but at least it lacked any noticeable oil stains.

Beverly herself had gone for a simple green summer dress, savoring the last of the season's warmth while she could. She made it look designer, despite coming from a big-box store on special, and it wasn't merely the few sewing tweaks she'd made. That was just Beverly. Something about her seemed to class up everything she touched.

It was a talent that was apparently rubbing off on Chloe, who'd donned a shirt and blouse combo far more ambitious than anything Tori had seen her wear before. Then again, she mostly saw Chloe at work and around the house, so perhaps she'd always had a fashionable streak.

Armed with wine, a new game, and appropriate outfits, they walked the short distance down the hall and knocked twice. Instantly, the door swung open to reveal Ellie, who clapped her hands in excitement at their arrival.

"Perfect timing! Kyle just ran out to grab us some beers, and Austin is grilling on the balcony."

"Which leaves me free to mix the cocktails." The shortest dweller of the apartment appeared from around the corner of the fridge as they made their way inside. He gave a deep, performative bow as greeting. "Ladies, I'm Ike

Fulton, and you may think of me as your personal bartender, butler, and whatever else you may require.”

Without so much as bothering to aim, Ellie took the sprayer hose from their kitchen faucet, turned on the water, and blasted Ike across his side with cold water, eliciting a sharp shriek. “Go change, and we’ll try that again,” she replied in the face of his withering glare.

Ike stayed planted for a few seconds longer, then assumed a casual grin as he trudged, chuckling, off to his room.

As he left, Ellie began helping Beverly unload. “Sorry about Ike. He’s not a bad friend—you can always count on him when shit gets real—but he has a nasty habit of coming on way too strong up front.”

“Interesting choice for a roommate,” Beverly noted. She was gently broaching the subject, carefully trying to set Ellie up to give them whatever backstory this apartment had concocted. It was the sort of delicate move that only she had a shot at pulling off.

“Yeah, that’s a really good point. Why do you all live together, anyway? Me and the girls bunked up after my apartment got torched in the Ridge City Riots, but I’m guessing that’s not the case for you all. You’ve got that comfortable vibe that comes from knowing people for years.” Chloe paused to look around the apartment, set up very similar to their own. This spared her the terrified expression on Ellie’s face: she was clearly not yet prepared to spin a backstory, let alone face an onslaught of questions.

Seriously, how were they so bad at this part of the job? Based on all the research Tori had spent her afternoon doing, they were proving to be extremely competent at every other aspect of being capes. Honestly, if she weren’t a secret villain hiding her identity, Tori would have definitely called it out by now.

Lucky for them, Beverly was more skilled at such operations.

“I bet you’re all old friends. Chloe is right, you all seem at ease around each other. Of course, you don’t have to tell us if we guessed wrong. I don’t want to repay your hospitality by prying.”

The visible fear left Ellie’s face as she recovered, thanks in no small part to Beverly buying her some breathing room. With a smile steadier than the rest of her expression, Ellie nodded. “You got it. Old friends, went to college together, and we decided to apply for jobs in the same town. Everyone got hired, so we opted to split rent and keep costs low.”

Perfect. Vague, with just enough detail to address all their major questions. It was the kind of story that wouldn't hold together well if poked, but so long as they—

“That’s awesome!” Chloe declared excitedly. “Where did you all grow up? What college did you attend? Oh, and where are you working? If it’s downtown, you’re in the same boat as me and Tori, though Beverly here gets to sit around and work from home.”

It was hard to be mad at Chloe for acting friendly, especially since she thought they were there to make new friends. Mercifully for Ellie, no sooner was the question asked than the front door opened once more and Kyle appeared, holding two cases of beer. Given that his ability was super-speed, Tori was going to be annoyed if those things were warm, though she should probably assume they’d all been shaken up in transport.

“Kyle! What good timing. Why don’t you tell Chloe all about our college and work experience? You always remember things better than the rest of us.”

Not exactly a subtle handoff, but to his credit, Kyle kicked into gear as soon as he understood the situation. “It all starts when I’m at my Intro to Calc class during freshman year, and I hear someone muttering curse words to themselves while staring at the book. He was saying what I was feeling, so I tossed over a greeting. That was the first day I met Ike—”

As it turned out, Kyle spun a nice yarn. He told a very convincing tale of four friends meeting, bonding, and ultimately setting off for a new adventure together. It held together well enough that Tori suspected large chunks were actually true, just with certain details changed. From what she gathered, they’d known each other for years. The exception to that was Kyle and Austin, who had apparently grown up together. Whether that was fully accurate or not, she definitely got the impression they had known one another longer.

By the end of Kyle’s story, almost everyone had gotten set up in the living room. Tori, Beverly, and Chloe were on a couch together while Ellie and Kyle selected kitchen chairs that had been moved in to surround a coffee table. Some board game about selectively blocking rivers to irrigate a valley had been preemptively arranged, but they were ignoring it until the time to play arrived.

Just as Kyle finished up the yarn, Ike emerged from his room in a new outfit that was near identical to the old, only dry, and helped himself to a

beer. “As I was saying, the name is Ike Fulton, and it’s...” Ike trailed off, looking to Ellie, who smiled sweetly. “It’s a pleasure to make your acquaintance. Sorry if I came on a little strong earlier.”

“You should hear what some of the customers say when they come in drunk,” Chloe muttered. “At least *you* were offering refreshments.”

“Speaking of refreshments, looks like Austin is bringing in our first haul.” Ellie pointed to the balcony, where they could see the hulking man carrying a sizable tray of food.

Steam was pouring off a few items, slightly obscuring Austin’s vision as he maneuvered for the door. He made it inside from the balcony, blowing away the steam so he could see clearly. “Grub is almost ready, but it needs to rest or you’re getting scalded.” As he began to head toward the kitchen, Austin surveyed the room fully, catching sight of their couch full of guests for the first time. Without warning, his eyes went wide and his steady steps turned suddenly clumsy.

This was a moment Tori would look back on and wonder, could things have gone differently? A little to the left or right, one iota more observant, and the night wouldn’t have turned out the way it did. In the end, such thoughts were little more than amusing distractions. There was no little to the left or right. Instead, Austin plunged his foot directly under a small section of the living room rug. In trying to take a step, he yanked up on the rug his other foot was holding down, causing him to fall face-first, sending his tray of sizzling hot meat flying through the air.

For the second time that week, Tori found herself staring down an oncoming projectile that should be less than an annoyance, yet because of those around her, she was going to have to risk injury. She shifted forward, trying to put herself between Beverly and Chloe. Heavy as that tray looked, the heat from the food wouldn’t bother her. The others might get burned if they were splashed by grease in the wrong spot. It was a noble instinct; however, also an unnecessary one.

What Tori had forgotten was that they were not merely having dinner with neighbors. They were dining with secret capes. And like everyone else who was committed enough to that job to join the AHC, they had instincts of their own. Kyle was there in a literal blur, putting himself between the food and the guests. Ike reacted nearly as quickly, making a motion with his hand that caused the laden tray to vanish, then reappear just before slamming into a wall ten feet away. The impact left a small crater in the

brick, and Tori was suddenly very glad she hadn't had to take the brunt of such a blow. How strong was Austin to fling something like that purely by accident?

As Austin pulled himself to his feet, silence dominated the room. Ike and Kyle were frozen, Ellie was trying to casually disperse the small flickers of energy she'd built up to block the tray if needed, and the guests were sitting on the couch, unsure of how to proceed. At this point, the jig was pretty much up. Unless they could think of some way to convince these four they hadn't realized what had just happened. Perhaps they could blame nerves or stress.

"Holy crap! I know those powers. You four are the New Science Sentries!" Chloe, of course, was the one to blurt this out.

Kyle surveyed the room, the shocked faces, the dripping meat along a broken wall, and his clearly caught-off-guard team. Silently, he went to the fridge, pulled out two beers, and opened them both. "Well, *shit*."



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## Chapter 17

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Through the history of humankind, metas included, there were doubtlessly other parties that had gotten off to worse starts faster than theirs—but not many.

Since Tori's goal had been to walk in and out, leaving as little impression as impossible, accidentally becoming privy to the New Science Sentries' secret identities was a significant complication. Playing dumb was out, thanks to Chloe, who'd finally caught on. It was interesting. Chloe wasn't stupid by any means, yet it had still taken her that long to figure everything out. Tori hypothesized that it might be an issue of perspective. One didn't look for hidden capes everywhere unless they needed to—but regardless, that was a point for later consideration.

“Ahem. Since we've just been outed as superheroes, now might be a good time for fawning and swooning.” Ike waggled his eyebrows when everyone looked at him, earning a few mild laughs. It wasn't a lot, but it broke the unbearable tension that had fallen much like the towering Austin, who was finally climbing to his feet.

“I am so sorry. My carelessness could have gotten you all injured.” He turned from the guests to his team, genuine remorse etched into his handsome face. “You all behaved perfectly. Protecting people always comes first. When we make the report, I'll accept full responsibility for the team's actions, and any consequence that comes with it.”

The mood of the party was dropping precipitously, which was fine by Tori. At this rate, they were going to be free before having to roll a single dice or make more than a modicum of small talk. The night would surely

have consequences down the line, but with a little time, she could prepare for those. Improvising her way through a dangerous social situation, on the other hand, was well outside her wheelhouse.

Finishing the first beer, Kyle took down a good portion off the second. “Like hell you will. We made our calls, and we’ll own them. But the bigger question is, what do we do about our guests?”

“Excuse me?” There was nothing fearful in Beverly’s tone; instead, it carried a hint of a threat. “Seeing as we’re law-abiding citizens here at your invitation, the only thing you’d better consider ‘doing about us’ is offering me a fresh drink.” She held up her empty wine glass to illustrate the point.

The rebuke earned her a sharp laugh from Ike, who looked over to the kitchen and waved his hand. One of the wine bottles vanished from the counter and reappeared in Ike’s grip. Another vanish—this time, wine plus all of him—and he was at Beverly’s side, pouring with needless elegance. “Ballsy. You seem like fun.”

“To elaborate, I’m sure that Kyle didn’t mean anything by that. He’s just nervous and flustered, like the rest of us.” Ellie appeared embarrassed, of all things: barely meeting their eyes, focused instead on the pile of steaming meat sizzling on the ground. “I mean... we haven’t even had a whole week in the field and we already let our secret identities slip.”

“Plus, you bungled my rescue,” Tori added. That earned her an elbow in the side from Beverly and a stern stare from Chloe. “Which is to say that everyone makes mistakes when they’re starting out. Broken eggs and omelets... all that noise. You’ll get better with practice.”

Another downed beer for Kyle, who went back to the fridge and brought back six new ones, stacking them all on the coffee table. “In case anyone else needs a drink. I appreciate it, Tori, but we’re not exactly fresh-faced rookies. We’ve been training to do this job for years, so you’ll understand why hitting so many early issues can be frustrating. Sorry again about putting you on camera. Actually, that’s kind of why we’re here.”

“No shit. I figured that out yesterday.” In her life, Tori’s propensity toward bluster had often been a necessary skill. It allowed her to project greater confidence than she felt, which was dearly useful when dealing with other criminals and lowlifes, as well as offered her a tough outer shell to hide all the childhood pain and loss behind. Unfortunately, the tactic cut both ways, and while this was certainly not the first time she’d talked a

situation into being more complicated, it was definitely her biggest verbal whoopsie to date.

Once more, Tori hoped that no one would say anything, and yet again, her hopes were dashed. This time, it was Ike instead of Chloe, though. “Hang on, yesterday? I know I’m good-looking enough to leave an unforgettable impression, but that’s why I wear the mask. How did you know who we were?”

Bad as this was, at least Tori could tell them the truth, since it had nothing at all to do with her own identity or the guild. “Tachyonic rescued me a few days ago, obviously. When we talked the second time, he forgot to speak all stiff and heroic. I recognized his voice when we met again. After that, there were only three very easy dots to connect.”

“Plus, we literally saw you holding up a couch with one hand,” Beverly added, pointing over to Austin, who immediately looked down at the floor. “That was sort of a tip-off, too. Next time, consider springing for movers.”

“You know what I love about all this?” Ike asked, dropping into a chair next to Ellie. “First week, we’ve got two major fuck ups, and I’m not responsible for either one. Somebody on the island lost a bet over that one, I guarantee it.”

A dark glare from Kyle brought Ike up short; apparently, he’d gone out of bounds even for him. “But seeing as there’s nothing to be done about it—they know, and we can’t change that—we may as well go ahead and play some board games,” Ike continued. “These three women now know our secret. Seems prudent we get to know them, as well.”

From her purse, Ellie pulled out a phone in a sparkling pink and white case. “I could order us pizza. It’s on the AHC’s dime, anyway. Technically, this whole thing is covered, since we’re on officially assigned guard duty.”

“Yeah, about that. This feels kind of unnecessary,” Tori said. “The press is already moving on, and while I do appreciate you trying to fix your mistakes, I can’t help thinking this is overkill. You have to live here just to watch over me? There’s no way that’s the procedure every time a civilian ends up in the spotlight.”

“I suspect we’re being taught a lesson,” Austin said. He’d recovered enough to make his way to the kitchen, pulling out cleaning supplies and eyeing his mountain of cooling meat. “The overkill is to drive home how much work it is to watch over someone constantly, making sure we go out of our way to avoid putting more civilians in similar situations.”

Or it was a way to embed four unwitting capes into Tori and Beverly's lives. Harder to commit crime with superheroes down the hall, was probably the rationale. Then again, maybe it was sincere. Tori had no idea if anyone on the capes' side knew her real identity. Given that she was publicly connected to Ivan, who they *definitely* had the history of, it was best to assume that at least the higher-ups had an inkling.

"For what it's worth, you can tell them I'm fine, and you're free to stop babysitting me anytime."

"I'll pass it along," Kyle replied. "But I doubt it will matter. We're here for at least a month, and then we have a reevaluation meeting. Until then, I can only ask that you put up with us. I promise we'll try not to get underfoot."

She didn't have a choice, really. It was the same options as before: play nice, or tell them to fuck off. Playing nice allowed her to set more boundaries, especially now that she knew they were here on assignment. Plastering on her best fake smile, Tori reached over to the coffee table and picked up one of the beers Kyle had set down.

"I guess somebody should call in that pizza. Otherwise, at this pace, we'll all be drunk before we finish whatever this first game is." Tori took a deep, long drink of beer, bracing herself for the night of socializing.



Emory didn't know what any of the tech was supposed to do, even as he supervised the installation. Sure, in the general sense, he understood this gear would keep their captive from being located by most known tracking means—although nothing was ever impossible—but he didn't fathom how setting up the few pieces of tech around the base was actually going to accomplish that. Deacon seemed confident, and all the rumors said this dealer sold working shit, so Emory tried to put his own lack of understanding out of mind. All they had to do was follow the instructions.

The focal point of the concealing equipment was a small, windowless room on the west end of the building. Since it had once been planned as a private office, there was a toilet installed inside, so that took care of their most disgusting logistical hurdle right off the bat. The walls were thick, and no one was around to hear, meaning that sound wouldn't be an issue, and

the tech would keep the capes off their backs long enough for Deacon's plan to kick in.

What that plan entailed, exactly, Emory was still uncertain. All he knew was that they were going to snatch the woman off the street, rather than try to take her at home. The apartment was tempting; however, breaking in came with too many static challenges. On a street, things were more fluid. They could strike at the opportune moment. After that, it was just a matter of transporting her back and getting word to the capes.

Taking a step away from the crew, Emory made his way down the hall to Darius's quarters. Just outside the door, he raised a scaly fist to knock, only to have the door open before he could make impact and reveal the serious face of Darius.

"Something up?"

"Construction is going well," Emory reported. "Should be ready by Monday. I was just wondering if there was anything else I should be doing. To prepare."

Darius looked him over, instantly spotting the question within the question. Being a henchman demanded a talent for talking around corners, questioning the boss's methods without ever letting them realize it. They lived a delicate balance between the crime lords and the capes. Most of the time, being a flunky meant no one paid you much attention when there was a bigger fish to chase. Get in too deep, do something really bad, and that wouldn't necessarily hold true. Worse, Emory was new. He didn't even realize the true danger of what they were contemplating.

"You should remind everyone that what we are doing is intended to be pageantry, nothing more. We scare the girl, we make the capes believe she's in danger, but we never use more force than needed for any given task. There is a tremendous difference between kidnapping a civilian to draw out the capes and injuring one."

"The charges would be more serious." Emory was right, technically, not that it would likely matter if he messed up.

Seeing that legendary, shadowy guild that every crook has heard some kind of rumor about drawn into the streets was a moment Darius would never forget. He'd listened to the same rumors, seen gangs vanish overnight, but he'd never *really* believed. He'd just followed the rules of surviving in Ridge City, which meant staying low on the capes' radars. Now, he wasn't sure if they were playing by the old laws or not. Seemed

unlikely the guild was still watching over crime, exacting revenge on those who broke their edicts. Still, no reason to take unnecessary risks.

“The charges, and the capes themselves, would be more serious. There’s a dance to some of this, and if you stick to the steps, then you can see where it will end. Break the rhythm, and you’re in uncharted territory. We play nice, because it ensures the capes play nice.” Along with anyone else who might be watching, though Darius didn’t add that last part. It was too much to try and explain, especially to someone who hadn’t spent years hearing those whispers.

“I’ll reinforce that along the ranks. Any word on when Deacon will be back?”

“He’s meeting his connection for the last round of supplies. After that, it’s just a matter of finishing prep, and then striking. Tell the others to be ready for when he comes back,” Darius instructed.

Emory hesitated, an uncommon act for him. “Shouldn’t one of us be along on these deals? We *are* his bodyguards.”

To that, Darius merely shook his head. “Kid, in this world, you need to square with the fact that different metas play on different levels. You and me are near the bottom: strong and deadly, but without powers that could break mountains or change reality. Someone with access to this kind of tech isn’t using the kind of muscle you or I could stand against. Deacon didn’t bring us because he’s smart enough to realize that if shit does go wrong, we’d just be more corpses on the pile.”



In actuality, Deacon hadn’t brought his goons because the seller forbade anyone else from joining him, and this was not a connection Deacon could afford to offend. Especially not at the incredibly low prices the tech was going for. To be fair, the gentleman across the table had brought along no guards either. He sat by himself, tall and gaunt, fingers steepled together patiently while Deacon inspected the wares.

It was a waste of time. Deacon had no better idea of how this worked than he did what made Lodestar fly. Nevertheless, he put on the show, because admitting ignorance seemed an excellent way to get fleeced.

Concluding the assessment, Deacon lifted a small tube with a single button on one side.

“Careful. The auto-injector has been preloaded with a cocktail of my own creation. Human, meta, alien, or elephant, that serum will take them down for at least three hours. It’s specially designed to block oversaturation and avoid an OD, so don’t worry about dosing. One press will fire the entire container. So long as you can break the skin, you can take her down quietly.”

“All reports say we’re dealing with a human, so I don’t anticipate that to be an issue.” Deacon slipped the injector back into the case, along with the other trinkets to equip their base. “Pleasure doing business with you, as always.”

Deacon shut the case and moved to lift it, but a hand on his sleeve stopped him. The gaunt man had leaned forward, pinning Deacon’s shirt with a single finger, his toothy smile shining in the soft light of the dangling bulb.

“There is one more thing. As your current operation has a high chance of drawing in some of those New Science Sentries, I thought I’d offer up a little something extra. Ten million dollars, or the tech of your choice, for each one of their heads you bring me. Except Agent Quantum. I doubt you’d even be capable, but nevertheless, that one has been reserved.”

It was an incredible offer, and one that Deacon had in no way been prepared for. “That is... generous. I’ll have to think about it. Killing capes is a little more ambitious than what we’d previously discussed.”

“Capes are like weeds. You want to pull them up early, before their roots burrow too deep.” Bony cheeks shifted as the toothy grin became a thin, hateful smile. “Trust me. There is nothing so troublesome as a cape once they’ve dug in.”

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## Chapter 18

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For the first time since the aliens briefly appeared in the night sky, Donald had the day off. His team had been running patrols and taking low-danger calls from the field all week, and while it was cool to see new cities even in short, action-filled bursts, he was definitely ready for a day to relax. Under other circumstances, he might have texted Tori, but the last thing she needed at the moment was to be publicly seen with another cape. Besides, even if they weren't working, he still had plans for the day.

Ren arrived downstairs first. After some trial and error, he'd managed to get the illusion device on his wrist fine-tuned enough to quasi-replicate something akin to how he'd looked before being transformed into the cape called Medley. His new body's proportions were all wrong for his old face — evidently, Ren hadn't previously been built like a walking tank—but at least he could pass as his own relative, albeit one that was way too into the gym. This was the face they'd begun to think of as Ren's default, the one he wore when he wanted to be recognizable.

"Team day!" Ren called, giving Donald a very careful high-five, making sure not to accidentally break any bones. Even if he looked and sounded human, the same fangs, scales, and muscles were still there, hidden under the facade, ready to be called on in a moment, if needed.

"Woo, team day!" Donald echoed right back. It had been Ren's idea, since he was the only one of them who was used to actually being on teams, but it hadn't taken long for the thought to snowball into something of its own entity.



“You two sound like goofballs.” The voice came from the stairwell, where Irene was finishing off the final step. Unlike Ren, her looks were constant: dark hair pulled back tight into a ponytail, piercing eyes taking in the whole room, and the barest smattering of makeup over her brown complexion. Granted, it was a change to see her outside of a costume or training sweats: fatigues, sneakers, and a shirt for some band he’d never heard of were certainly a different kind of fashion, yet it still managed to be quintessentially Irene. Comfortable, functional, and with only the barest of shifts given toward how it actually looked. Were Apollo still in charge of the rookies, he’d have never let her out in public like that, even though her civilian identity wasn’t yet known.

She approached them, let out a very loud sigh, then lifted her own hand up for high-fives. “But that’s about what I expect from you dorks, anyway. Yay team day, rah rah rah, let’s go have some fun.”

It was the most enthusiasm she was going to show; that was just who Irene was. Now that Donald and Ren were used to it, they knew she was excited as well, even if she didn’t demonstrate it in the same way. More hands were slapped as they waited for their final member to appear.

True to form, Lucy arrived at the edge of being late, looking slightly as though she’d tumbled all the way there. Her black hair was a mane trailing behind her, a flush highlighting the freckles along her pale skin, and she was hopping on one leg, slipping a sneaker onto her left foot. She was the only one who’d opted for shorts, despite the lingering summer heat, and paired with the plaid button-down, Lucy looked more suited for hiking than a day on the town. It was curious to Donald how she could be something of a mess in her day-to-day life, yet prove constantly reliable in the field. At any given time, he was never quite sure how Lucy might be managing, but he’d quickly learned that Hat Trick could be counted on when the world turned into chaos.

“Team... day!” Lucy puffed out that last bit; she’d definitely jogged down to the garage to meet them on time. “Sorry, got caught up on a call. Am I late?”

“Don’t worry, madame executive, your call didn’t impact your next meeting.” Irene met Lucy with a hug, and then commenced the final round of high-fiving before they would depart. “Hey, Donald, where did we end up deciding to start, anyway?”

That choice had actually been made for them. When everyone pitched their contributions to team day, Donald had taken everything down, and then looked at what could feasibly be scheduled for a single outing. Irene's was easy, since the park was open all day, but Lucy's only had showings at night. Ren's was the toughest, though thankfully, it had lined up well when they discovered one of Donald's ideas had recently expanded their hours.

"We're going to start by doing brunch at the downtown arcade restaurant. Reviews say the food is good, and either way, they'll still have the huge selection of classic games," Donald informed them.

Ren narrowed his eyes. "Any items in these classics we should be aware of?"

"Doubt it, although I am kind of curious to see what would happen if I ate a ghost-killing dot. Doesn't matter anyway. Remember: today, I'm just Donald. After brunch, I found us a football game to watch. We're apparently still too early for the pros, but some of the colleges are doing preseason stuff. That work for you, Ren?"

"Is one of the teams the Ridge City Ravagers?" Ren asked.

"Sorry, they weren't playing today. We could always see if they've got practice—"

"No." The word was firm, yet spoken gently. "Not ready for that. They are... were my team."

In the earlier days, when it was just Donald and Ren, they'd have stood around awkwardly fumbling their way out of the unexpected conversational pitfall. Those days were gone, however, and they were no longer a duo. They were part of a group now, which meant that some of the members actually did know how to deal with these kinds of moments.

Lucy strode over with the sort of determination Donald more commonly associated with Hat Trick, wrapping her arms around Ren and hugging him as tightly as she could. It was comical, in a way, this comparatively small woman squeezing with all her might on the hulking figure; almost like a child hugging a statue. Until the statue tenderly hugged her back, at which point, it stopped being funny and started to make Donald realize he needed to better his interpersonal skills. Working with other metas, these kinds of situations would come up, and the awkward fumbling routine wasn't going to cut it forever.

"Since Lucy wants a show, I'm guessing that means we do my thing third?" Good old Irene: not someone you'd want for a smiling competition,

but always willing to shoulder her way through an awkward pause to get things moving again.

“Got it in one,” Donald confirmed. “After the game, we drive a bit out of town to Candoo Memorial Park. There’s a colony of meta-butterflies migrating through there, and they say it’s like watching a living rainbow fly around the sky. Weirdly, this was the hardest one to get tickets to—I had to go through official AHC channels to even get in the door.”

“Well, it’s not a video game, but the natural world does okay from time to time.” If Donald didn’t know better, he’d have thought he detected a hint of mirth in Irene’s tone. “And after that, magic?”

Their hug concluded, Lucy turned away from Ren, eyes lighting up. “Oh no way, did you really manage to get us in?” She was rocking on her heels, nakedly excited in a way that uncomfortably reminded Donald of himself discussing a new game release.

Donald nodded, earning a small squeal of joy from Lucy—the only warning she gave before she enveloped him in a hug as well. Unlike Ren, Donald was not composed of animal parts and muscle, so he could actually feel how much force she put into them. The woman loved to hug; it wasn’t shocking she’d grown good at it.

“Four tickets to the Amazing Earl.” Donald forced the words out, earning himself a reprieve as Lucy eased her embrace. “I double-checked: you know this guy is human, right? He’s not going to be doing anything you can’t.”

“It’s not the same,” Lucy protested. “I’m using real magic. He’s using technique and skill. How do I put this...? If you won a game with a cheat code, you wouldn’t say you’d beaten it, right? Same thing. I like having this power, but I still want to be good enough to do magic on my own.”

That was actually an amazingly adept analogy, Donald realized. He was impressed. They hadn’t been working together for all that long, but she’d perfectly conveyed the point using language he understood. Maybe he should ask her for lessons on communication. Since Ren was already shoving Donald into the gym regularly, he’d quickly gotten used to idea of learning from his teammates. It was something to think about—just not on their day off.

“Well, with these seats, you should definitely have a good enough view to figure out the Amazing Earl’s secrets. On that note, do we have anything

else to add before we requisition a driver? I figured we'd just do meals as we saw stuff that looked good, or I could make a reservation for tonight."

"You've done plenty." Lucy laid a hand on his shoulder, far more daintily than when she'd gone for a hug. "Thanks for putting this together for us."

"Team building counts as training," Donald replied. "Plus, learning about the things we all love is a great way to do that team building while also having a killer day off. I was happy to help."

Really, he was happy to just feel like he was contributing. During the Ridge City Riots, the rest of the team had taken a serious beating protecting Cyber Geek, because he was the key to their plan. While it had shaken out okay—largely thanks to Lodestar arriving just in time—Donald could still feel the guilt over that day in his gut. How badly they'd been hurt, and how terribly things could have gone, while he'd come out virtually unscathed. Donald was determined to do better, to be better, and if this helped in even a small way, then it was effort well spent.

A large SUV pulled round, driver at the ready. Together, the team piled in, heading off into Ridge City for some well-deserved time to recover. It was fortunate timing, too, given how hectic the next week was going to be.



"You're the new cluster leader?" Janet ran a thumb along the edge of her glass, a tell she was annoyed that Ivan still remembered quite clearly. Sitting in her parlor, the two of them were talking quietly. Juan had taken Rick and Beth out for a day at the museum. Ostensibly, their mother was helping a fellow professor with a last-minute emergency and would catch up. These sorts of talks were easier in private.

"Should I even ask what happened to Haywood?" She flexed her fingers, reaching for a cigarette that wasn't there. If he squinted, Ivan could still remember the way Janet had looked when she smoked. Still pretty, if perhaps too serious for some tastes, but back then, there had also been a wild, chaotic energy around her. From the chopped-up hair to the half-shredded clothes, no one would have guessed that under it all hid the brain of a mathematics prodigy. In a way, that had been her version of a villain identity, but it was one she'd long ago cast aside.

“Haywood Gibson was involved in an unfortunate car accident that has left him unable to fulfill the duties of a cluster leader. As a willing parent, I was tapped to take his place, at least until a suitable substitute can be found.”

Her dark eyes roamed over him. There weren't many people who knew Ivan, not really. Janet was an exception. Former wife, mother to his children, she'd spent more time with him than even Wade had during their early villain days. That was another reason Ivan preferred contact over the phone. She was too good at reading him.

“I knew that guy was up to something. It was about her being a meta, right?”

Weighing his options, Ivan decided that this was not the time for subterfuge. “Mr. Gibson seemed to have some preconceptions about metas being around human children. I was planning to use my contacts and go around him. Then he decided to speak about Beth directly. Plans changed.”

A smile. Brief and quick, but for a moment, Ivan saw the old Janet, the dangerous woman too smart and bored for her own good, peeking out as a twinkle in her eyes. “Those kids are going to face a lot of hell growing up as the children of Fornax. Beth even more, now that she's got powers. For all the complications having you as their dad adds on, I'm glad you're here to watch over them.”

It was a pleasant note to end things on. Unfortunately, they hadn't actually reached the end of their conversation. There was still another point to raise.

“There's one more thing you should know. All clusters have a male and female leader—a policy meant to accommodate the kids in case they want to discuss embarrassing or private matters. I won't be leading these meetings alone. The one who put me in this position is going to be there, keeping watch on both me and the children.”

Whatever good cheer had found its way to Janet's face drained off. Her thumb was pressing so hard against the glass it was turning the skin white, not that she appeared to notice. “Really? That's the story? She's there to keep an eye on you, in case you decide to, what, kill a room full of kids? Even in your worst days, Fornax never hurt a child, and she of all people knows that's still true.”

“She's putting Fornax in a room full of minors; no one else would agree to that without Lodestar being present,” Ivan pointed out.

“Fornax isn’t the problem!” Janet slapped the table, and for a moment, her old fire was no mere twinkle of the eye. “God damn it, Ivan. You’re single, so I don’t give a shit if you two want to play these cute little games, but I wish you hadn’t just jammed our daughter into the middle of it.”

Silence fell as Ivan quietly weighed his options. “If you feel that strongly that it will be bad for Beth, I can see if there’s another way. Perhaps a different cape she’d trust to take the spot at my side.”

“You should do that. I should make you do that.”

Janet closed her eyes, breathing deeply, before releasing the death-grip on her glass. “Except, I can’t,” she continued at last. “Because no matter how I feel about all of this, the attack on their school showed me that our kids can be targets, despite every assurance you offered through the years. If Beth can spend a few hours every week endearing herself to the world’s greatest superhero, I have to let her. She might need that alliance one day, when the world finds out what her dad’s old job really was. And if someone attacks her again, she’ll be high on Lodestar’s priority list. This is bullshit, I’m laying that out up front, but the kids come first.”

“Always.” Ivan didn’t hesitate, nor did Janet question the response. As a couple, they’d been fair, at best, and as exes, they were even worse; yet on this point, they were absolutely united. For all the faults and issues they had between them, Ivan knew that Janet always acted with their children’s best interests at heart, and vice versa. It was the common ground that had allowed them to manage custody.

Janet continued to look at Ivan, studying his every change in expression. “Just... don’t let her do what she does. Don’t let her get in Beth’s head. Please don’t let her steer our girl toward that life.”

That promise was not one that Ivan could make, though he wanted to dearly. He could no more stop Helen from inspiring people toward goodness than he could outmatch Lodestar. They were forces beyond him, past his realm of halting. Nevertheless, Ivan would give his all. Janet was spot on: the last thing they wanted for either of their kids was for them to fall into the world of crows and masks. Beth being a meta would be hurdle enough for her; if she started into Ivan’s world, there might be no way back.

“With everything I have, I will try.”

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## Chapter 19

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Monday found Tori returning to her mundane routine, with the added spice of now knowing everything she did was in the proximity of a team of capes specifically there to keep an eye on her. Saturday had gone well enough; they'd exchanged pleasantries and played board games for an hour or so before finally excusing themselves. It felt like the New Science Sentries had enjoyed the visit, once everyone had recovered from the shock of accidentally outing themselves, so hopefully, they weren't suspicious of their new neighbors.

Just to be safe, Sunday had been an extremely mundane affair. She, Beverly, and Chloe went out for lunch, caught up on work, and watched some old movies; things she imagined people without secret meta-lives did frequently. Truth be told, it had been a nice day off, and Tori found herself more refreshed as a new week began than when she spent ninety percent of the weekend hunched over in a lab. Maybe there was something to the idea of taking weekends as actual breaks.

By the time she made it to work, Tori was almost thankful to see Vendallia. Boring as it was, here, she was one more cog in the machine. No one paid her particularly special attention, nor did she have to take great pain to appear normal. Simply being here every day and doing the work made her own case for normalcy. People with better options didn't often stick around in positions like Tori's.

Upon arrival, she found Ivan waiting for her at the door. Tori lifted an eyebrow, unsure if something was up, but Ivan merely handed her a brown

paper bag with the top folded over and stapled together. “Good morning. I trust you’re feeling rested from your time away.”

“Oh yeah, a week dodging cameras was my perfect idea of a vacation.” Tori pressed along the bag, feeling the soft contents inside give way. “Is this a welcome back gift?”

“If you want to think of it like that. It’s your uniform for tonight. I procured it from the specialty tailor you use; I know how some synthetic fibers can give you a rash.” Ivan didn’t tend to be the type to make jokes, so Tori was half-certain he’d chosen that cover story because it explained why half the shit she wore was custom tailored and not because it was inherently embarrassing. She wasn’t going to object, since it still netted her clothes from the special material that could be shifted into fire. While Tori was capable of making the material herself, she didn’t have nearly the sewing or fashion skills Doctor Mechaniacal had access to, meaning the provided versions were of optimal quality.

Yanking off the staples, Tori peered inside. She had to root around a little, but the outfit quickly took shape. Not very different from what she remembered Starscout assistants wearing when she was a kid. Tan shirt and pants—maybe shorts; it was hard to gauge length in a bag—along with a turquoise ascot. She’d brought sneakers from home, which would round out the ensemble. There were also hats, if she recalled correctly, though those were for actual outdoor activities.

“Hang on... if I have to wear this, does that mean...”

“We will all be dressed appropriately tonight,” Ivan said, answering the question preemptively. “Myself, you, and our other cluster leader. While she’s an old contact of mine, you wouldn’t have met her yet. She is unaffiliated with Vendallia or its major partners. Do try to keep that in mind, and use discretion as appropriate.”

There were doubtlessly more subtle ways to tell Tori the other person wasn’t a secret villain, but these weren’t the sorts of messages Ivan left to chance. “Got it. Be on my best behavior, and no talking about confidential company work off the clock. I won’t even bust out my inventions or technology talk. Do I get to know the name of this mystery helper before we arrive, or is that supposed to be a surprise?”

“Helen.” Ivan looked briefly away, glancing down the street to where the morning sun was beaming down on cars and commuters coming from the east. “Her name is Helen.”





She watched as they scampered about, looking down from the balcony much like Apollo had when examining the same group. Newer members of the AHC were kept in the same part of the base for many reasons. Bonding, comradery, safety, training—it was easier to consolidate people of roughly the same skill level, which was to say, amateurs. That was how all rookies were treated when they came in: assume they knew nothing and drill the fundamentals. Every now and then, a street-level cape would bristle at having to prove themselves, but since Lodestar had yet to meet a single person who didn't benefit from retraining the basics, the policy remained in place.

Except that it had been months since the last confluence. A lot of the so-called rookies had been logging hours nearly nonstop, taking every patrol and shift they were offered. No doubt some of that came from the desire to prove they weren't aligned with Apollo or any of the others who'd illegally set up the guild of villains, yet she knew there was more.

They'd all seen a flash of the old world. Before guilds and peace, before the AHC, when everything was chaotic and dangerous. People liked to look back on the older days with a patina of wistfulness coloring their impressions. Not her. She could still remember the times at the end of the League of Heroes, when Professor Quantum had all but checked out entirely. Things were near a boiling point back when she was a street-level cape herself, a period of her life few people even knew about. To the world, Lodestar had burst onto the scene in a sudden blaze. The public hadn't seen her before that moment, when she was just one more set of fists on the sidewalks trying to help. They had no idea about the years spent working in anonymity, before she ascended to her role as one of the world's most famous protectors.

That was the trouble with metas, humans—all living things, really: they changed. People grew up, grew stronger, grew better. It was natural and inevitable. Unfortunately, that also meant she now had a whole group of rookies that were no longer truly on the same level lumped together. It was time to start graduating some of the units up to harder jobs, take the stress off the over-worked capes. Since the guild's outing, low-level crimes had increased constantly. It wasn't that Ivan's people had been actively stopping that many operations; more that fear of them had forced the bulk of

criminals to be careful. Without that fear and need for caution, crooks were getting bolder. Sooner or later, they'd make a true push, and the AHC had to be ready when that day came.

Powerful as Lodestar was, she was still only a single superhero. It was a hard truth she'd accepted decades prior: not even she could save everyone. The world was too big, too full for her to have a prayer of managing that. That was why capes worked together, why the Alliance of Heroic Champions had been founded: to share the burden of keeping the world safe. To have capable allies always at the ready. To teach the next generation how to use their abilities, and then entrust them with the future.

Finally, Lodestar looked right, to where Quorum was patiently waiting. "I'm guessing whatever files Apollo had on them are already largely out of date, though I'd still like to look them over. But even after being left on their own while we were getting everything sorted, they've all been improving. I checked the logs last night. Some of these teams are doing near constant field patrol. No telling how that experience will show itself."

"With respect, there *is* a way to tell." Quorum's voice was as patient and near neutral as always. "It would not be the first time the Champions' Congress has evaluated the skill of our recruits by hand. For a time, that was the only method we had. There is a case to be made for the tried and true tactics."

The groan that escaped Lodestar's lips almost had a weight to it. "I hate doing that. It's not fun for them, Professor Quantum takes it way too seriously, and inevitably, somebody quits when they see the power difference. Can't we come up with rubrics or something?"

"Apollo used a complex ranking methodology that took into account potential merchandising appeal, camera skills, and perceived loyalty to the organization. I presume that system wouldn't be to your liking, but properly vetting and assessing them all one by one using our old metrics will take quite a while. If your concern is to make sure the ones ready to advance are being used and trained properly, then that method will waste a lot of time."

Doing the right thing was supposed to be the easy part. Except that when you were in charge of a whole organization, it demanded balancing different versions of that "right thing" depending on who one looked at. Was it more right to slowly assess the rookies in this case, keeping them from helping people in need, or to get more capes onto the streets, even if they might not be ready to step up? It had to be done right—there was no

room to give on that front, and sooner was definitely better. Quorum, to no surprise of Lodestar's, turned out to be right.

"If it's going to be a hands-on evaluation, let's at least be smart about this. Tell Professor Quantum I'm doing the whole group solo. Assuming he cares enough to ask why, the excuse is that since he's got clear bias toward the New Science Sentries, this will keep the assessments beyond reproach."

"Do you really think he'd go easy on his team?" Quorum asked. It was the kind of question he didn't actually need to say; he'd already found the answer before the first syllable hit his lips. These were for her, and the sake of conversation.

"Heck no. I think he'd decimate them in front of the entire AHC just to shame them into working harder. But it's more about the image than the truth, and that's a concept he'll be on board with." She looked down once more, observing the costumed figures as they darted around. "We'll have to do it in one go. If word gets around, things'll get muddled. Can you schedule everyone else so that I've got all the rookies one day on a weekend?"

From his pocket, Quorum produced a folded sheet of paper. "I'd already begun work on assessing the best options for doing so."

"Of course you did." A quick scan showed several schedule options, rotating their members around in different shifts to ensure the AHC was ready to respond to any serious threats. It didn't escape her notice that Quorum's own name appeared in a few spots, jammed in among all the others like it was nothing special. "You want to go back into the field?"

"It would be more apt to say I feel compelled to go into the field," Quorum said. "As you noted, the people are in need. While, for a time, I best served our organization by helping to run it; such attention is no longer required. The Alliance of Heroic Champions has grown vastly in its decades. It can endure without me working behind the scenes, and there are many voices reminding me that our power comes with a duty to help. One in particular has been especially ardent."

Quorum met Lodestar's eyes, and suddenly, they weren't his anymore. For a flash, a different iris appeared, just long enough to give her a wink.

In the beginning, that alone might have caused Lodestar to tear up. Now, she smiled back, thankful to have the moment at all. "That sounds nice, but this place has been big enough to run itself for a long time. Lack of support staff wasn't the only thing keeping you in here."

“Of course not,” Quorum agreed. “I was ‘holding down the fort,’ as the saying goes. I knew one day you’d both return. Now that there’s leadership I can trust, I’m not quite so worried about leaving the place unattended.”

Seven years. That was how long she’d been away. It felt like a drop in the bucket to her, but for the world and the AHC, it had been different. She didn’t regret the time off after the birth; Helen had always been ready to come back if the need arose. Except the world had managed to stay out of major danger, thanks in no small part to Ivan and his guild keeping their own kind of peace. For seven years, she’d gotten to be a normal person, raising her daughter. Coming back meant there was a lot to clean up, yet Lodestar felt strangely energized.

Those years had reminded her what it was she was fighting for: all the normal people out there who wanted nothing more than to live in peace with the people they loved. Up high, looking down from the clouds, it was easy to forget that every dot on the ground was a person, with their own dreams and life connecting to untold others. Living like a normal human helped her remember why they were so worth protecting. Helen was never going to have that peaceful life; that she’d even gotten to taste it was truly a miracle. So she’d settle for protecting that peace for as many people as she could.

“Do the third schedule option,” she instructed. “And please, whatever message you give, don’t tell them they’re sparring with Lodestar. Last time, that caused three panic attacks before we even got the test running.”

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## Chapter 20

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If Tori hadn't known better, she might have thought they were pulling up to Ivan's actual house. The neighborhood was boring enough to match his old one, and the home itself looked like the same kind of predesigned build. It was a little too nice, however. Stone work on the exterior, designer touches on the trim, this was the home of someone who spent more for appearances, which took Ivan instantly out of the running.

"Whose place is this?"

"Technically, Vendallia's," Ivan replied. "We have some rental properties in holding for when visiting staff are needed on long-term projects."

"Or if someone guild-related needs a place to lie low away from headquarters?" Tori might still be relatively new, but she could spot a pattern that obvious.

"I suppose that might also happen, in theory." Ivan reached into the back of his car and scooped up a large duffel bag, presumably containing his own outfit. "Though, to my knowledge, we've mostly used them for their intended purpose. We got an official exception since my current home is too small to host in and this is work with a charitable organization... with perhaps a dash of help from the top."

Tori snickered as she reached for the handle, but Ivan laid a hand on her shoulder. "Listen: before we go in, I want to make sure we're on the same page. While the kids will be kids, you'll also be working with another adult. Be aware of what you say. This isn't a busy office, and Helen is no distracted coworker."

“She someone I should watch out for?”

Something odd appeared on Ivan’s face, an emotion somewhere between amusement and consternation that ultimately faded as he released a slow, controlled breath. “Whatever conclusions you draw about her should be your own. I will only say that she is not a woman I would advise you underestimate.”

After watching an entire team of capes accidentally out themselves over the weekend, Tori was in no mood to take anyone lightly. One slip-up, one spilled tray of meat—that was the difference between a secret identity and her name on the Hephaestus rap sheet. Since she had to be here regardless, Tori was treating this as supplemental self-control training. If she could hold her heat and hide her power around a room of preteens, there wouldn’t be much that could rattle her.

Together, she and Ivan made their way up the front drive, arriving to find the front door already peeking open. Pushing through, they could hear humming come from within. Tori noticed that silver and turquoise streamers were already running along the ceiling, hanging over a large dining room table that had been enthusiastically cluttered by craft supplies. Movement drew her attention; she focused on a doorway to the kitchen as a form stepped into view.

The woman was still humming, earphones poking out from underneath her mane of chestnut hair. She was younger than expected, mid- to late-twenties at most, only a few years older than Tori herself. And that was assuming the glasses didn’t make her seem older than she really was. As this stranger, presumably the mysterious Helen, turned around, she caught sight of Ivan. Instantly, her face lit up and she set down the armful of glue in her grasp.

“Perfect timing. I’ve got the decorations working and our fun-time table mostly ready. You need to get moving on grub. Given the age of our group, if there aren’t adequate snacks, they might chew through all this lovely rental furniture before the night is through.” Helen looked away from Ivan for the first time, treating Tori to a full-force blast of smiling, cheerful energy. “Hello there! You must be Ivan’s niece. Thank you so much for agreeing to come help us out. I look forward to getting to know you over the coming weeks, Tori.”

Tori went for a handshake, which Helen somehow managed to turn into a hug, seemingly without effort. If not for Ivan’s warning, it would be easy

to mark Helen as a happy, simple helper, the kind one might let their guard down around. No wonder Ivan had cautioned her about underestimation. Helen was the type of person Tori would instantly dismiss, and he knew it.

“My pleasure,” Tori said once the hug finally ended. “But you’ve got me at a disadvantage. You’re aware I’m Ivan’s niece. How do you and my uncle know each other?”

Part of her had expected some big reaction. Instead, Helen calmly tapped a finger to her chin. “Oh goodness, it seems so long ago—you know how the years get jumbled. We’ve run in similar social circles for ages, and eventually, we met. He’s a bit of a stick-in-the-mud, but a dependable fellow most of the time. Helping out here was the least I owed him after Ivan pitched in with the local kids’ theater play last year. My daughter was a sugar-plum fairy. I think I can find pictures, if you’re interested.”

Right, the kids. Tori forgot that people with children were forced into social situations, whether they liked it or not. Even for someone like Ivan, the act of showing up and being a dad meant he’d deal with other parents. Evidently, he didn’t hate all of them. Tori could see the logic; Helen had the sort of infectious, positive energy that could be hard to resist.

“Perhaps we should head down that road after the meeting. There’s only a few hours, and I’ve seen you go into a picture-showing session.” Ivan set down his duffel and headed for the kitchen, only to have his arm hooked by Helen as he passed.

“Aren’t you going to put the uniform on?” Helen gestured to her own body, which was clad in the tan, short-sleeve button-down and matching capris, topped off by a turquoise ascot. The summer Starscout uniform, to be changed out with something warmer when Autumn arrived. “That goes for you, too, Tori. Meeting regulations.”

For a moment, Tori felt the ground vanish. She was a child again, standing in her room as her mother explained that, yes, they had to go to the meeting; yes, she had to visit with other kids; yes, she had to wear the uniform. It was a memory tinged with childish anger and frustration, but Tori held onto it for as long she could. There were only so many memories left where she could still recall her parents’ voices.

When she blinked herself back to reality, Tori noticed Helen watching her. “You okay? Seemed to space out there for a moment.”

“Sorry, I’m fine. First day back at work, just a little tired. I’ll be good to go by the time the kids show up.”

“Why don’t you go ahead and change? I’ll put Ivan on task in the kitchen, then you can help me with decorations,” Helen suggested. She led Tori down the hall to a large, stylish bathroom that was much too big for the intended purpose.

Once Tori was tucked away, Helen returned to the living room, where Ivan was pulling his own uniform out.

With one hand, Helen took Ivan’s forearm, silently leading him to the kitchen, where she proceeded to yank out pots and pans. “Little cover noise, just in case. While she’s changing, is there anything you need to bring me up to speed on? Major changes or revelations we should knock out before the kids arrive?”

“To my own surprise, I’ve got nothing to report. No sudden threats or dire stakes sprang up, no foreboding signs that one of our charges is secretly a doomsday weapon—nothing. Seems to be a class of mostly mundane kids. Beth is the only catalogued meta in the bunch,” Ivan said.

“Fingers crossed that turns out to be true.” Helen paused, laying a giant sheet pan carefully down atop the stove. “These kids deserve normalcy, no matter who their instructors are. But, if anything *does* go wrong, I’ll handle it.”

Ivan looked up from the kitchen counter, where he’d been eyeing ingredients. “I’m not sure that’s—”

“Ivan, this is Beth’s cluster.” Sometimes, it was strange to hear that level of authority come from Helen rather than Lodestar—until one realized how many of the differences between them were merely cosmetic. “I know you’d expose your secret to protect her. You’d do it without a second thought or an instant of hesitation, which is why I’m telling you now, up front, that I’m in charge of dealing with problems. My secret has protection. Yours doesn’t. Your daughter is going to be here, watching. Worry about her; I’ve got everything else.”

There was no value to arguing. Besides the fact that Helen made excellent points, ultimately, it was the one she hadn’t said out loud that Ivan found most compelling. If a situation arose demanding one of them to get serious, then it would have to be a reasonably dangerous one. In that scenario, with trouble at the door and children to protect, Helen *should* be the one fighting. She was stronger than Fornax in his prime, and now, the divide between them was even greater.



“Over the years, if there is one lesson I have taken to heart, it is that you’re going to do what you say, no matter what,” Ivan conceded. “Just try not to jump the gun. Let’s see if we can resolve things without leaning on our full power.”

“Hey, I still got my moves.” Helen bobbed and weaved, mostly as a joke, yet it was impossible for Ivan to miss the practiced steps in even her playful offense. The vast majority of the world thought Lodestar won by sheer power alone, and while that was certainly true much of the time, the public wasn’t privy to her past. They didn’t know she’d logged her years as a low-level street cape, learning to fight through constant practice.

It was an educational tactic Ivan knew all too well from his own childhood, if one could call his raising by such a term. In another life, he might have liked to spar Helen cordially, with no powers involved. Sadly, such was a mere fantasy, and this was not the time for indulgences. Ivan turned his attention to the real task at hand: whipping up some hot snacks.

After all, if a group of kids on the cusp of teendom showed up to find no food, the cluster leaders might need Lodestar’s protection after all.



Nexus strolled down the boulevard, passing a designer pet boutique and a veggie wrap stand that shared the same building. Ridge City was nothing if not experienced with recovery. When the Garbublux broke through Professor Quantum’s containment zone and went on a rampage, it had taken years to get fully back up and running, even with the League of Metas pitching in to help. Jump forward several decades, and Ridge City recovered from its eponymous riots in the span of months.

Already the streets were bustling as people ran their Monday evening errands, so worried about their plans and dreams, looking ahead to days that were in no way guaranteed. In the beginning, Nexus had almost felt for these mindless masses. They didn’t know what he knew, couldn’t see all the iterations he’d seen. They had no idea their world was at risk. They didn’t spot the slithering in the shadows, the old grudges blooming once more.

Of course, that would all need patience. Big, beautiful machinations didn’t set themselves up overnight. Fine art required time and effort to craft,

time that Nexus didn't begrudge the artist. Still, that didn't mean he wasn't going to enjoy the lesser spectacles while he waited.

His casual stroll came to a sudden halt as Nexus passed the front of a bookstore. A malicious grin appeared below his kaleidoscope eyes, which were obscured by the brim of his low-dipped hat. Walking in, Nexus made his way to the back, rifling through a few sections until he spotted a good fit. Paying no mind to the employees, Nexus returned to the front display and exchanged one of the visible books for his selection. Tossing the original display into a discount bin, Nexus stepped back outside to admire the handiwork.

Perfect. That would provide the extra delay needed. Spinning around, Nexus scanned the roofline. Now that he'd ensured there would be a show to see, the next step was finding the best seat in the house.



It was controlled chaos. To Ivan and Helen's credit, asserting any level of control over a group of four girls and three boys was damn near a meta-human feat in itself, especially since they hadn't gotten together in months. The collective of growing mouths had chewed through everything Ivan could churn out, and toward the end, Tori wasn't sure he hadn't used a little magic to fudge the cooking times.

As their charges arrived, Tori made a point of learning their names quickly, determined to appear competent. The first on the scene was Newton, a young boy who Tori had yet to see sit, stop, or even slow down for longer than it took to grab a snack. After him was Mallory, who brought in a knapsack teeming with books that made her look somewhat like a turtle always just on the edge of tumbling over. Caden came next, and with him a nonstop string of questions and inquisitions that Helen mercifully had enough patience to either be or appear entirely unbothered by, even after hours of interrogation. Armand came along not long after, carrying with him a hatbox that Tori found rather curious—at least until Trudy arrived. When she walked in, Armand handed over the box, and from it, Trudy produced one of the most garish pieces of headwear Tori had ever witnessed, from the neon pink top to the zebra stripes along the band. It must have been just what she wanted, though, because Trudy wrapped

Armand in a giant hug. Beth was dropped off soon after, greeting her friends cheerfully. While they were busy, Loyce wandered in, calling out a quick greeting before making a detour to sample Ivan's culinary creations.

By the time the last child was present, things had gotten *loud*. Thankfully, Helen turned out to have a talent for wrangling children. After watching her work for a few minutes, Tori could easily understand why the woman had this position. There was something about her demeanor, gentle but firm, that quickly struck the right chord. By the time Helen had gone through the general welcome, she had the attention of everyone in the room. Until Ivan walked in, of course.

His outfit was near identical to Helen's, save only that he'd chosen knee-length shorts over capris. In any other setting, Ivan likely would have stepped into a field of chuckles and some, at best, good-natured ribbing. However, this was perhaps the single scenario where he didn't seem remotely out of place. No, it wasn't the funny outfit that put the attention on Ivan.

That honor belonged to Beth, who applauded with shouting enthusiasm as he walked into the room, prompting the other Starscouts to join in. It was strange, hearing them call Ivan "Mr. Gerhardt" and realizing that most of these kids thought they knew him. He was their friend's dad, likely an acquaintance of their parents; the man no one had any reason to think twice about. How strange would it be, to only know half of someone? Tori couldn't imagine; so far, she'd always met the secret personas before the covers, or it had been blatantly obvious like it had with Donald or the New Science Sentries. At this point, she was actually starting to wonder if any of the capes managed real secret identities.

"Tori, when you've got a moment, I could use a hand at the dining room table." Helen had walked over while Tori was lost in thought and Ivan was addressing the cluster. "Tonight is mostly just getting back in the swing of things, but we've got some crafting planned for the back half of our time. Trust me when I say you do not want to see a glitter project without proper tarping laid down."

From the half-circle of kids grouped up around Ivan, Beth looked over, catching Tori's eye and giving her a soft wave. They hadn't gotten to speak yet—Beth was dropped off only moments before the meeting had to start—but it was clear she remembered Tori from their last encounter. Well, the last one Beth knew of. Technically, they'd been together when Beth and

Rick's school came down, but Beth could hardly be blamed for not knowing. Tori had been sealed away in the armor of Hephaestus at the time.

Treating herself to a chuckle-inducing look at Ivan's exposed shins, Tori headed over to help the other cluster leader with the crafts. At least she didn't have to busy herself wondering how to appear especially regular or mundane. If Tori wanted to come off as normal, Helen seemed like a fine example to follow.

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## Chapter 21

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In any given day, any moment really, there exists untold possibilities. At any second, a person could stand up, walk through a door, and change their life. Few do, of course, because the appeal of infinite potential outcomes often pales in comparison to the daily worries that permeate one's mind. Instead, people fall into habits, routines—limiting their possibilities in exchange for a fleeting glimpse of consistency in a chaotic world.

For all her technological genius and criminal ways, Tori wasn't special in this regard. She, like so many others, had a typical route she took: catch a car toward the office, disembark at the end of the block before traffic slowed to a crawl and walk the rest of the way in. Sometimes she would stop at Ridge City Grinders when there was time. It had become her pattern since moving out of Ivan's home, and on that Tuesday morning, still groggy from a night dealing with children, Tori didn't even contemplate approaching the office differently. Her mind was on the day ahead, and the potent espresso she'd be ordering before she faced it.

The day was nice, a bit of early fall winds balancing the late summer heat—not that Tori was bothered by high temperatures. It was one of the few side-perks of her powers that extended to her human form, and there was something satisfying about being the only one dry when the rest of the office was sweating. Since the weather was pleasant, she took her time, walking slowly down the spacious pedestrian sections.

If not for memory, Tori would never have known this area was struck by looters during the Ridge City Riots. The attack was short-lived, since Beverly and Chloe had driven them out, yet even the lingering signs of

damage had been swept away within weeks. Concrete repaired, glass reinstalled, and just like that, downtown was back to normal. Sometimes Tori wondered how many times this city had been repaired like that. How much of this place was even still the original Ridge City?

Walking past a bookshop, a cover displayed in the front window caught Tori's eye. *Building Infinity: The Wade Wyatt Story* was a favorite of hers for years, though now that she'd met the man, her faith in its accuracy was deeply shaken. Seeing as none of the biography had mentioned him being Doctor Mechaniacal, faking his own death, or being friends with Fornax, it seemed like a safe bet that she shouldn't assume anything in those pages to be factual. Perhaps she could get the real story out of him one day. If he was going to tell the truth to anyone, it would probably be a member of the guild.

It was thanks to being momentarily distracted that Tori didn't notice the dark van creeping up along the nearby alley beyond the bookstore. She missed when four men hopped out as well. It wasn't until Tori caught shadows approaching her from behind in the window's reflection that she realized something might be up.

Spinning around, she was faced with four identical balaclavas covering the men's faces. One of the men stepped forward, trying to grab her.

In that moment, Tori had to make a decision. There were people all around; it was a Tuesday morning in downtown. If she used her powers, there *would* be witnesses. Probably a cell phone video, the way her week was going. Any chance she might have had of not getting recognized was toast thanks to last week's media exposure; she much too fresh a face for someone not to recall. Using her abilities needed to be a last-ditch resort. If things got dire, she would have to wield that tool in her arsenal, but there was no reason to start with it. Especially when she had plenty of other options.

Tori slammed her palm into the face of the man reaching for her, then spun to her right and kicked another in the side of the knee. She could hear cartilage tearing over the sound of his scream, but not by a lot. Someone tried to grab her left arm, earning themselves an elbow to the nose for their trouble. Since he reeled after the first blow, Tori added a second, forcing him to finally back away. Blood stained the facemask as he sputtered out curses in a nasal voice.

“Come on, you cowards. What’s wrong? Expected this to be easy? You dipshits think I’ve never taken a self-defense course? This is Ridge *fucking* City. We know how to survive out here. At least until *someone calls a cape.*”

The fight was quickly drawing attention. Civilians were pointing, yelling, and, as predicted, pulling out their cameras. Tori hoped the line would assuage anyone wondering how she was holding four attackers at bay, but mostly she wanted it to get other people involved. She wasn’t winning. She was buying time. Against these numbers, she needed either her tech or her powers; without them, this was just a stalling measure.

When Tori felt the next hand close on her, she knew the jig was up. It was too big. There was no way this wasn’t a meta. Sure enough, moments later she was lifted into the air, meeting the eyes of fifth attacker who’d apparently come over when the first four couldn’t close. His face, too, was obscured, though the build gave away that he was a muscle-based meta, most likely as tough as he was strong. Probably still flammable, if she was willing to play that card publicly.

“Hurting you isn’t part of this, but if you keep fighting, it might have to be.” Calm, collected, in control of the situation despite things spinning out of hand. This one was dangerous; all the more so because the hulking types were usually underestimated mentally—according to Thuggernaut, anyway. If he was smart enough to know how to do this right, then maybe he also knew he shouldn’t be doing it at all.

Tori laughed in his face, loud and harsh. Her words, however, were soft, meant only for the man keeping her bound. “Hurt me? You world-class fuckheads are kidnapping a citizen in the middle of broad daylight on a Ridge City street. We both know how this ends. Your crew is as good as dead. The only question left is whether or not they die screaming.”

The eyes widened; she’d definitely hit home. Unfortunately, while Tori had been putting the fear of the guild into someone, another attacker was also busy. She didn’t see the injector. All Tori felt was the pinch of metal sliding into her leg. There was a split second where she could have shifted to fire, but with the terror rolling off her captor, it seemed a better bet to keep her secret for now. Only seconds later, when the first wave of drowsiness hit, did Tori realize her mistake. What she’d mistaken for a stabbing was, in fact, a drugging.

“Cheating... sons of... bitches.” That was her last conscious thought before she went limp in her still shaken kidnapper’s arms.



“Come on. We need to go!” One of the voices was helping the man with a freshly injured knee back to the van. People were still milling around; however, seeing the woman go limp had invigorated a few, there was likely to soon be trouble.

Darius delicately set Tori on his shoulder, taking great care not to injure her. How the hell did she know about the rules, and that they were breaking them? Kidnapping was obviously against the law, but doing it like this was against the *rules*, and that mattered far more. Certain things got people vanished, and shit like this was definitely in that category. The most likely answer was that it was a bluff, something she knew a speck about and happened to guess near the mark. But something about this woman didn’t sit right.

Normal people couldn’t fight the way they saw in movies. There were limitations beyond just skill or strength. To actively hurt another person with intent wasn’t easy. It required a specific mindset, usually developed through training. People held back, they tried to do only as much damage as a threat required. Not this woman. Tori had only gone for crippling blows. Without hesitation, at that. Every strike she threw came with the intent of breaking the people around her, and when she succeeded, she only went for more. Given the situation, it was an understandable mindset, just not one a civilian should have been capable of.

As the van peeled out back down the alley, taking the preplanned escape route, Darius made certain to keep their captive safely in his grip. Until he knew more about just how much they’d bitten off, it was best to play things cautiously.



It was a bit early for a phone call. Ivan grabbed the cell off his desk, noting the number. The company on the ID was guild-affiliated in the same way as Vendallia, in that they were an Indigo Technologies subsidy owned by



Wade Wyatt. These tended to be the easiest ways to pass semi-private messages around, since they both raised no suspicion and could be claimed as confidential company conversations.

Picking up, he was unsurprised to hear the voice of Xelas. Her tone, on the other hand, was immediately off-putting. Xelas was not typically prone to concern. “Ivan, this is Alexis from Confide Messaging. We’re reaching out to you in regard to your niece, Tori Rivas. Based on the trending information available on social media, it appears she was just kidnapped off the street. If you’d like to watch for yourself, I’ll wait on the line.”

The fact that Ivan could type without shattering his keyboard in that moment spoke to how much control he’d gained through the years. He opened up a new tab, skimmed past blog posts questioning if Lodestar had lost a step in her time away, and clicked on the rising trend. If he hadn’t known the victim was Tori, the hashtag “#RidgeFuckingCity” would have given it away.

Watching the video, Ivan was surprised. He hadn’t anticipated the sense of pride rising in his chest as he saw Tori handle herself without so much as a spark of heat in sight. She’d done wonderfully, fully selling herself as a human being fighting with everything they had. Hard as she fought, once the syringe was injected Tori quickly went limp. At least the brute carrying her into a van had the sense to be careful.

When the guild was exposed, Ivan knew this day would come. The edicts they imposed through whispers and carried out in the shadows couldn’t endure once the guild wasn’t around to enforce them. Common criminals had been growing bolder and bolder. Now, they were actually stealing people off the streets. Were their target anyone else, Ivan would have left it for the capes to handle. The AHC wanted to have the whole game to itself, so the guild was planning to let them... except that now, it was complicated.

Not just because they’d kidnapped Tori, which involved Ivan on a personal level. That, actually, would have been much easier. No, the issue here was that they’d kidnapped a member of the guild. Even if the crooks had no idea, it didn’t matter. One day, the truth could come out. This world ran on respect and power. The guild endured because it was unassailable, and to challenge them held blood-soaked consequences.

“I’m assuming the myriad of security protocols in place mean there’s some way to track her,” Ivan said. “Tell our favorite nerd I’m coming in.

Let's establish contact first, then see how she wants to play it."

"You want to let her run the show?" It wasn't the surprise in Xelas's voice so much as the amusement that worried Ivan.

"If someone managed to get you off the street, would *you* let anyone else run point on making them pay for it?"

There was a stretch of silence, and when Xelas spoke again, it nearly sent a real chill down Ivan's spine. "No, I'd definitely want to be the one to peel them. All right, Ivan, get here as soon as you can. Since this is national news, the company wheels are already turning to get you let off work. See you soon."

The phone went dead, but Ivan didn't set it down yet. Instead, he punched in a number he knew by heart but was not saved to his phone. It rang five times, then went to voicemail. If Helen wasn't answering, then she was most likely busy. Given the events of the morning, Ivan could make a wager on where her attention was being demanded. It would have been nice to talk with her, lay down some ground rules, and stay out of each other's way. Nice, but unlikely to happen, even if the call went through.

This was a declaration: a kidnapping in the AHC's backyard, of a woman one of their members just saved. The message was clear. They were calling out the capes. Besides being an intensely dumb thing to do, that wasn't the sort of gauntlet the AHC could ignore. People needed to trust the capes for that system to work. If the trust failed, it all went tumbling down. The AHC was going to come at this one hard.

Which just meant it was all the more important that the guild handled things first. Once the capes were involved, everything grew vastly more complicated. It was much easier to slaughter people wholesale without superheroes around. In the end, that would be up to Tori, though. She was the one who would bear the most consequence. She should decide how to handle things.

Assuming, of course, that she was okay. Because if Tori *wasn't* okay—an idea Ivan was working hard not to entertain—then things were going to get messy. Ivan would make certain of it.

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## Chapter 22

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The car smelled the same. If pressed, Tori would have said that there was no way she could recall the scent of her dad's old sedan, yet as she sat in the back seat, the odor was instantly recognizable. As were the two figures seated up front. Just the sight of their shadows, obscured by the cursed sun coming through the windshield, was enough to make her heart crack. Her mom was driving, playfully swatting Tori's father's hands while he fiddled with the radio. They laughed, and he leaned across the seats to kiss his wife on the cheek. For a moment, it was perfect.

With all she had, Tori wanted to touch them, hold them once more. She reached out, her hands small, too small, the way they were when that horrible day came. Her arms strained, trying in vain to move a little bit closer, an inch at a time, struggling to so much as brush their skin.

Instead of touching her parents, Tori only managed to shake herself out of the dream, coming back to consciousness as the pain of her wrists tugging against metal became more and more pressing. Waking with a start, Tori realized she was handcuffed to a chair. In her sleep, she had been trying to reach up, which had caused the metal to bite into her flesh. Shaking her head rapidly, working to shrug off whatever drugs she'd been given, Tori took several deep breaths, then evaluated her surroundings.

Cement all around: no windows, a single toilet, one door, and a pair of wireless cameras posted at opposite corners of the room. Tori bit back a curse. If not for the cameras, she could just fire-form her way out of the handcuffs and find a crack to slip through. Then again, that would still leave the mystery of how she'd escaped, which might stir unwarranted trouble

down the line. She didn't even know who had her yet, or what they wanted. There might be smarter ways to play this than running for a door.

Forcing her brain to calm down, shoving aside the emotion her dream had stirred up, Tori thought hard. This was a situation where every variable had to be considered. First and foremost, she needed to remember that right now, she was here as Tori Rivas. No one in the gang knew about her connections; otherwise, they'd have steered clear or killed her outright. This was not the proper level of restraint for a guild member. As Tori, her options were limited: wait for rescue, maybe talk some shit.

There was, however, the possibility that these people didn't just want a damsel. They might want a victim, too, something to send the capes a bloody and harsh message. In that case, Tori would have to take a back seat to Hephaestus, suit or no. It wouldn't be an easy fight—they had numbers, resources, and at least one strong meta. Her best-case scenario would likely be to escape, leaving survivors who knew her secret. Perhaps the guild would be able to mop them up, but there were no guarantees.

Tori also had to consider the possibility that the big one knew enough to realize how badly he'd fucked up. If she could wear on that pressure point, make him realize that they'd just broken a rule with serious consequences, she might convince him to set her free. Overly optimistic, certainly, but right now, Tori could do with a little senseless hope.

As things stood, her best bet was to play the part of the captive human. If the capes found her first, she'd be what they were expecting. On the other hand, if the guild arrived first, she'd just take some light teasing for letting herself get captured. Technically, there was a chance that neither would find her, though Tori considered that to be borderline ridiculous. However, with metas, one could never be fully sure. The right power at the right time could make all the difference.

The clang of a lock turning was her only warning before the door swung open. In stepped a freckled man with tissues stuffed up his nose, a meta with visibly snake-like features, the big meta, and a couple of goons milling about in the rear. The freckled one with the jacked-up nose started forward quickly. While not the world's most socially aware villain, Tori had been around enough scumbags to recognize a posturing walk when she saw one. Her elbow to the nose had hurt his ego, and now he was looking to reclaim some pride.

“Looks who’s up. It’s our little fighter. Those were quite some moves, Miss Rivas. Did your friend Tachyonic show them to you? Perhaps without the mask on? You’ll find us excellent hosts to talkative guests.” Her captor’s voice was cloying as he circled the chair, moving out of her line of sight for stretches of time. It was meant to make her unsure, worried about what he’d do behind her back. Instead, it was mostly annoying, since he was harder to hear at some points of the spiel.

For all her forethought, in that moment, Tori realized she had neither the inclination nor the patience to pretend in front of these idiots. She’d just have to hit the pressure points hard and hope they let her go fast. Subtlety was never her strong point; Tori preferred an upfront confrontation. At this point, it was more for their sake than hers, anyway.

“God, you’re fucking stupid. I mean, sincerely, do you have some amazing power? Can you fight on par with Professor Quantum, run as fast as Ricky Rocket? Or did you win all these people over with meta-level handjobs? Because it damn sure wasn’t your deductive skills. Tachyonic and the rest of the New Science Sentries arrived last week. If you think I learned to fight like that on seven days of training, then you should be trying to recruit me, not asking dumbass questions.”

That was not the answer most of them had been expecting. Only the big meta seemed largely unfazed that she wasn’t crumpling or afraid in spite of the situation. Freckles, the one talking, had a moment of visible panic, but lucky for him, he was facing Tori at the time. The rest of the gang didn’t see the fear that ran through him. He was trying to reassert control, and Tori wasn’t letting him have it.

“Brave, bold words, no doubt born of certainty that the capes will save you,” her captor said. “But I’ll let you in on a little secret. We procured technology specifically designed to keep them from doing just that. Think hard about your next words. There won’t—”

“I’m sorry, did you say you had tech to keep them out?” Tori didn’t hide the incredulity on her face. In fact, she made it as obvious as possible. “You want to use *technology* to stop *Professor Quantum*.” She leaned back, blowing idly into the air. “Christ, man, what’s next? You going to try to light Infernical on fire? I can’t believe you’ve managed to figure out how not to shit in your pants, given what you’re showing me so far. Have you, actually? Those slacks could hide a diaper, now that I look closely. Tell me if I’m talking too fast or need to use smaller words.”

The skin between those freckles was getting red, a sign of her constant backtalk clearly getting to her captor. Still, he tried to retain control while his peons were looking on. Leaning forward, he took a firm grip on her shoulder. That drew a slight bit of concern from the big meta, though he didn't step forward entirely.

"Listen here." The freckled man's voice had turned into a hiss, all false sweetness vanished. "I can be a good host, or a cruel one. Do not mistake my hospitality for weakness. Hear me well on this point: if you test me, I will give you the discipline you so clearly crave. That is my promise to you. But if you can compose yourself, perhaps you can make it through this alive."

It was a good speech, the scariest bit he'd managed so far. In another life, it might have worked. Even before the guild, she understood self-preservation enough to soothe some sociopathic egos. Except that this kid, whoever he was, didn't scare her. *Couldn't* scare her, unless he was hiding a massive ability. He wasn't in the league of people she socialized with, to say nothing of the ones she genuinely feared. None of them were. They were playing on the edge of a vast chasm, with no idea of the horrors that lay a single slip away.

"Okay, if we're laying things out, then here's my counter-proposal: let me go right now, and there's a chance your gang will survive."

Laughter from the back, and from the captor seconds later. Not from the big meta, however. He was the one Tori made sure to meet the eyes of as she continued.

"Yeah, it's funny. I get that. One gal, tied to a chair—what's she going to do? Just don't get it twisted, dipshit. I'm not threatening you: I'm warning you. Maybe you didn't get the news somehow, but what you did today is a major no-no. On a lot of levels, in fact. You're about to piss off people you don't even want to know your name, let alone be mad at you."

Here, the freckled fellow finally found something to pounce on. "You think we're afraid of the capes? We're doing this specifically to confront them."

Tori's frustration began to bleed over. "Listen to me, you walking corpse. You'll never see the capes. You'll never get whatever fight you want. By the time they arrive, you'll be nothing but smeared pulp and charred stains along the walls. I'm trying to warn you while there's time to change that. Your enemy won't fly down from the skies, they'll sneak up

from the shadows. By the time they're here, you won't even have time to piss yourse—"

As far as backhands went, it was fair, at best. The guy clearly hadn't done much muscle or combat training, but then, it wasn't really about the damage. It was about the hit itself, reminding Tori that he was free and she was a captive, supposedly at his mercy. The sound of his hand striking her face faded slowly, echoing around the stone room.

"I think I gave you more than ample warning. Now, cease with the senseless blathering. We'll leave you alone to collect your thoughts. When I return, you will start answering questions, or I'll have to be an ungracious host once more."

The rest of the crew took the order, filing back out through the door. Before they were gone, Tori's voice rose once more.

"Hey, Big Man. I tried. If you care about any of these people, take a swing at convincing them." She paused to lick the corner of her mouth, where a small trickle of blood was oozing out. "As for you, Freckles, don't worry about any of that."

She sat herself up straight, looking him dead in the eyes, making sure he understood every syllable. "You'll die wishing you could scream. That's *my* promise to you."



Despite his hands being clasped together as he sat, Darius wasn't praying. Even if he were the religious sort, this didn't feel like a situation where divine intervention would be on the table. No, Darius wasn't lost in prayer, he was lost in thought. That woman was off, and in more than one sense. The brutal way she'd fought, her demeanor during interrogation, the things she kept hinting at. She *knew*. She was connected, in some way. Maybe to a cape, maybe to something worse. But this was not the way a normal person behaved in a kidnapping.

The larger question was what he could do about it. Deacon ran things, even with the broken nose and that shitshow interrogation. He had to be the one to make the call, or Darius might as well just stage a coup. Deacon was smart, despite how he'd handled himself. The trouble was that he was smart in a way that involved patterns, puzzles, and planning. Seeing past his own

ego wasn't in that toolkit, which meant that even if Deacon had been open to listening before, there was zero chance he'd be receptive after Tori had humiliated him.

If Darius couldn't let her go without staging a mutiny, and he thought there was even the smallest chance she was telling the truth, then his only option was to deal with Tori directly. Maybe he could sell it as good cop to Deacon's antagonistic style to get the boss's nod. Whatever story he concocted, Darius had to get in there with her. He could figure out how much was bluster versus how much was actual knowledge, and in the worst-case scenario where she was telling the truth, hopefully he'd have laid the groundwork to get his people spared.

Except for Deacon, most likely. Even in the most optimistic of situations, if Tori was telling the truth, then the boss was a goner. Darius had heard enough dangerous people talk to know the difference between a threat and a vow. Tori hadn't been making a threat—which was one more oddity to add onto the pile. Part of him had even considered the idea that Tori was a cape herself, but that didn't track. A cape wouldn't have needed saving in the street, and she certainly wouldn't have let herself be abducted.

He didn't know exactly what Tori's deal was, but he needed to figure it out, and soon. At least one thing she'd said was right on the money: Deacon was absolutely crazy if he seriously expected black market tech to hold off Professor Quantum.



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## Chapter 23

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By the time Ivan made it to the guild council's new chambers, he was almost the last to arrive. Wade was standing at a computer terminal, punching the keyboard while barely looking, Xelas standing over his shoulder, adding the occasional bit of advice. Morgana had traded her usual business casual ensemble for something armored and blood-red. With her abilities, clearing out a base silently was a task she often received. Gork was sitting patiently in the corner, waiting to see how things developed. Only Stasis and Arcanicus were missing, neither of whom were immediately necessary.

"Where is she?" It had taken discipline to walk here calmly, to not do anything so dramatic as leaving footprints in the stone or knocking doors clean from their hinges. That patience was wearing thin, however. With every passing moment, they knew less about what had just happened to one of their own. For innumerable reasons, that would not stand.

"If you'll give me a moment, I'll tell you," Wade replied. "As I hope you've assumed by now, all the shifting clothes we give Tori have specially encoded tracking devices. Makes it so much easier than hiding them one by one like I have to do with the rest of you."

That was the sort of thing Ivan might have objected to under normal circumstances, which was no doubt why Wade had chosen this moment to divulge the tidbit. The man wasn't called a genius for nothing; he knew how to use an opportunity.

"All we have to do is link up, and I should have her coordinates," Wade continued.

“If it’s that simple, shouldn’t you have them already?” Ivan hadn’t exactly stopped for coffee, but he’d come via mundane routes, taking roughly an hour. There was no chance Wade needed that long to ping a simple tracker.

Sure enough, a crease appeared below his thinning copper hair, a telltale sign that Wade was slightly annoyed. “Whoever took her was smart enough to employ some countertracking methods. The signals they aren’t blocking, they’re scrambling. Xelas and I were finding a workaround to connect with our devices. In fact, you arrived just in time.”

With a flourish, Wade pressed several keys, eliciting several beeps and one loud buzz, followed by flashing red lights. Wade and Xelas both leaned in, staring at the screen, then one another. While Xelas was able to keep up a stoic front, Wade didn’t quite manage the same. His pale face reddened as he checked the information over several more times. When he turned back to them, it was with the gravity of the guild’s leader.

“Somehow, they’re still blocking. We got a connection, reached out to the device, but they’ve employed a tactic to halt any real communication. While I realize that this might not seem like a larger concern than what we were facing, please understand the severity of what I’m saying. If they’re using tech able to disrupt mine, then it has to be of roughly the same technological capacity, or greater. As things stand, there are only three living people in the world who can create on that level: me, Professor Quantum, and Tyranny. I’m not working against myself, Professor Quantum would never lower himself to dealing with street criminals, and Tyranny has spent decades observing an isolationist policy that I doubt she’d break for some quick black-market cash. Outside of a known entity throwing us a hell of a curveball, the most logical explanation is that there’s a new player.”

“A new player with some skills,” Xelas added. “I never caught the designing bug like Wade, but I can still analyze the complexity of the programs we’re seeing, and it’s far from amateur.”

“Which means this is no longer just some punks grabbing the wrong person off the street. We have to consider the possibility that it was targeted, the opening shot of a war.” Morgana finished buckling on one last bracer, completing her preparation.

They were all making very good, reasonable points. Things that should definitely be considered. When Tori was safe.

Striding forward, Ivan closed the gap and glared at the still-flashing red screen. He turned from it to Wade, actively working to keep his eyes from shifting to their rune-filled forms.

“Find her.”

“Relax. That’s what we’re about to do.” Wade put his hand on his old friend’s shoulder, trying to keep him calm. “It will take a little time, but I’m going to reconfigure the tracker’s communication system until we can slip around the block they’ve got in place.”

“How?” Ivan asked.

Wade met his question with a carefully raised eyebrow. “Do you want the five minutes of me condensing complex concepts into techno-jargon, or can you just trust that I know what I’m doing?”

After a deep breath to get himself under control, Ivan gave a quick nod and stepped away. It was easy to let himself spin out, to give way to everything inside him scratching to break free, but that wouldn’t help Tori. He needed to be ready to act when Wade gave the word. Much as he appreciated Morgana donning her work clothes, there would be no need for silence or subtlety in the approach. Not once Ivan was on the scene.

“In the meantime, we should try to establish communication with Tori,” Wade added. “Gork, would you show Ivan to Mind Mirror’s new accommodations? With tech temporarily at a roadblock, that leaves magic, and psychic bonds form a lot easier between people who are familiar with one another.”

The huge gray creature rose from her seat, lumbering over to lay a large hand across the entirety of Ivan’s back. “She’ll be fine. No one gave her membership into this guild—Tori earned it. Don’t forget what that takes, or what it means. She’s a danger, not a damsel, and they probably haven’t even realized it yet.”

Despite being one of the least human among them, Gork had a knack for knowing the right thing to say. The points raised were valid. Tori was far from helpless—at worst, he should probably be worrying about how to get rid of five charred corpses before the capes could show up. All the same, Ivan would feel much better once he knew Tori was actually safe.

“Thank you, Gork. Let’s go find Mind Mirror. I’d very much like to check on my former apprentice.”



“Blocked? How is someone blocking *you*?” Even as she said the words, Lodestar knew she should have taken a different approach. Professor Quantum’s ego was his tenderest spot, especially where she was concerned, and the fact that someone was stopping his satellite scan had to be weighing on him already.

Sure enough, there was a telltale bristle as he looked back to the giant screen that showed only an empty map. For a man his age, Professor Quantum had never grown especially adept at concealing his annoyance. Or maybe he was a master of the skill and merely chose to not employ it. It never paid to make assumptions where Professor Quantum was concerned.

Together, they were standing in the Chamber of Champions, a near relic from more active times. Across the walls and ceiling were screens capable of displaying all manner of images, both flat and three-dimensional. There were also tables, computers, and other stations filled with stuff boasting varying purposes that Lodestar couldn’t remember. During the AHC’s early days, this place had been their hub, the place they’d spend time coordinating to take down threat after constant threat. Over time, order had won out over chaos once more, bringing things to a peaceful equilibrium. They’d held that order for a long time, but one had only to look at human history to know that every era of peace was but a temporary ceasefire.

“It is concerning,” Professor Quantum agreed. “Granted, I am working with minimal information about this woman and no devices local to her body. Yet it was also inevitable that as the masses inch their way toward technological progression, some exalted minds would use that springboard to fuel their own creations. New minds are born daily. It’s hardly shocking that one managed to develop something of use.”

It didn’t feel like he was telling her everything, but then again, what else was new? That was Professor Quantum. He’d agree to alliances, join organizations, and work with others to the extent he needed to, and never a single step more. It was more accurate to say they all worked alongside Professor Quantum, rather than with him. Sometimes, Lodestar wondered what he’d been like back in the beginning. Was he jaded from the jump, or was there a time he’d cared?

“What’s the game plan? At this point, they could be anywhere in the world. It’s been more than long enough to utilize a teleporter, and if they can block you from tracking them, then they were obviously prepared.”

“The plan?” Professor Quantum was an absolute master of the dismissive stare, and the one he sent her was among his finest works. “I am not one of the soft-faced children roaming our halls. I know who this woman really is. Are we sincerely pretending that this is a good use of our resources? She is a member of that damned guild, and what they lack in decorum, they make up for in brutal efficiency. A scan was one thing. However, we both know those hoodlums will be a pile of limbs before we can ever track her down.”

“Maybe.” Lodestar ran her hands through her glowing hair, causing it to drift out around her head like she was in low gravity. “But if someone built a device capable of blocking you, it would certainly be able to stop Doctor Mechaniacal, too.”

There wasn’t even a second of consideration from Professor Quantum. “That goes without saying.” At least that giant ego cut both ways.

“Think about this: what if they don’t have her location yet? What if we can beat them to it? Aside from the fact that Tori was snatched publicly, on the street, and so we should be the ones to save her, imagine the look on Doctor Mechaniacal’s face when he realizes that you got there first. We might not be able to touch the guild legally, but you can still remind them who the world’s true greatest genius is.”

And, in the process, they’d get the gang into the courts, rather than letting them be slaughtered over a single mistake. Professor Quantum wouldn’t see validity in that, naturally, but Lodestar didn’t care about his motivations nearly as much as his actions. It was a peace she’d been forced to come to decades ago.

This time, there was a brief pause as Professor Quantum thought over her words. Seconds later, he pulled a communicator from his hip and pressed the button to speak. “Quorum, since you’re down with the field teams, please begin prepping them for search and rescue. We are officially launching an effort to recover Miss Rivas. Feel free to inform the media of that as needed. I’ll join you shortly once preliminary plans are in place.”

Lowering the communicator, he looked over to Lodestar. “Have you considered the potential consequence of these actions? How much worse will it be if we deploy our resources to save this woman, only for our people to stumble upon the carnage of her true rescue?”

“If we find her, I’ll be the first one in,” she replied. “That’s just good sense, anyway, since I haven’t gotten to vet the new teams. That limits their

risk, both physical and mental. Make sure they know their job is just search, not rescue.”

“What would you tell the press, were such a scene uncovered?” Professor Quantum probed.

“The truth. That when you enter the world of criminal metas, you’re stepping foot onto a dangerous path where we can’t always protect you. I’ve tried and failed enough times to know I can’t save every person all the time. So has every veteran member of the AHC. We do our best and mourn those we fail. It’s the way of the world.”

Lodestar took three steps toward the elevator, then began to float. “In the meantime, I’m going to zip out through the roof and do a patrol. If Tori’s calling for help, there’s an off chance I could hear it.”

“She won’t be,” Professor Quantum said.

“No, she won’t,” Lodestar agreed. “But someone will be. I was gone for a long time. I’ve got making up to do.”

“Don’t let them get too dependent. You know where that leads.” For once, there seemed to be a note of actual concern in Professor Quantum’s voice.

Ignoring the array of button, Lodestar popped open a hatch in the top of the elevator, one that had been made especially for her. Sometimes, she needed to make a very speedy exit, and going up through the ceiling made for the fastest way out that didn’t involve fixing a wall.

“I’ll keep it in mind. Give me a buzz before you send out the masses. We should talk to them together, make sure they understand the situation.” In a flash, she was gone, through the top of the elevator and out the escape hatch concealed on the roof.

Professor Quantum watched her go: a flash across the screen, the sort of moving energy that it would be harder to not track. All that power, and yet she constantly coached restraint. Maybe that played well with the humans, so timid and fearful of losing a superiority that had long since deserted them. They wanted her to be like them: mortal-adjacent. For someone who knew that woman’s real power, it was exhausting. They truly had no idea what she could do, if only she would take a position of true leadership, one of control. The closest Lodestar had come was changing how wars were fought, yet even then, she’d handled everything so delicately. Were he in her position... well, it wasn’t worth going down that mental road.

As for Professor Quantum, he had tasks of his own to complete. Lodestar's obvious play to spare the kidnappers had presented him with a fine opportunity. He'd trained a team that was the most capable on staff, yet was failing to make a dent in the public consciousness. This was an excellent chance to give the New Science Sentries the PR push they really needed.

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## Chapter 24

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With an empty concrete cell around her and only a pair of blinking camera lights to look at, Tori didn't have a lot of options in terms of external stimuli. In this case, it paid to be an obsessive scientist who'd spent most of her life alone. Rather than waste the time being bored or giving in to worry, she focused on pondering the revisions to her suit she was planning. Mentally reworking the power structure and shifting design features was more than enough distraction to lose herself in, so much so that Tori almost didn't notice when time stopped.

In her defense, the only way she had to know was the blinking lights, which both suddenly stayed lit up without warning. At first, she thought the kidnappers were messing with her, or their computers had crashed. Then she saw the first crack appear.

It came from a corner of the room: a sharp break in the world, like she was viewing a reflection through a broken mirror. Except the crack was three-dimensional, and growing. Another came from near the front camera, then she started to see them growing out from somewhere behind her. The room, the world, fractured around Tori until it was virtually unrecognizable. In front of her, where the door to the room should be, the cracks converged into a singularity. There was something in there, something moving. Tori strained her eyes, trying to see. As she did, a faint whisper of a word met her ears, a lost voice on the wind.

*"Apprentice."*

Not necessarily an accurate title anymore, but an excellent way to let her know who was calling. There was only one person who had ever, or



likely would ever, call Tori by that term. Ivan was reaching out, a thought that filled Tori with unexpected relief.

As the feeling flooded her, the convergence of fractures swelled, then burst entirely in a shower of light.

When it cleared, there was a hole in the world, one cutting between her and what appeared to be a plane of outer space, complete with a sea of stars shining in the background. From that hole, Ivan stepped forward, looking like his usual self, only more annoyed.

“Tori, I know you have a guarded nature, but in the future, when you’re kidnapped and an obvious meta reaches out to help, consider relaxing your mental grip a tad. Mind Mirror is going to need a meal and a nap after what it took for him to punch through, even with me helping.”

“Only you would find your former apprentice kidnapped and go right into a lecture,” Tori said. The annoyance was feigned. Inside, she was nearly overwhelmed with joy to see him. She could back up her tough talk to an extent, but that was a drop in the bucket compared to the kind of vindication he and the guild represented.

Ivan examined her surroundings briefly before making his way over. “We can all stand to improve. Never hurts to have someone coaching us along.” His gaze turned to Tori, who was largely fine, if one ignored the small stain of blood on her mouth. The wound itself had already closed and was well on its way to healing—even outside her fire form, Tori mended faster than normal, just not meta-fast. Still, Tori saw the flicker of rage in Ivan’s face when he noticed it, largely because he did such a shit job at concealing the anger.

“Doctor Mechaniacal is currently working to find your location; whatever tech they’re using is high-end enough to give him trouble. That’s a much larger problem in itself, but one issue at a time. We established a psychic bond to check in, and see if you could provide any clues to your whereabouts. The more you can tell me about what’s happened, the better a chance we’ll find you.”

Dutifully, Tori rattled off the tale of her abduction and interrogation as best she could recall. While a few tidbits probably did get skipped over, she hit all the major points in quick succession. Ivan took it all in stoically, sometimes nodding or scowling at a certain point, but for the most part, he simply listened.

When she was done, Ivan paced the room, his feet making no sound as he walked.

“This is quite a hornet’s nest you’ve wandered into. As I’m sure you can guess, the AHC is hunting you. With the media hounding them about the kidnapping, even the most cynical personnel have reason to be motivated. That said, tech that can stall Doctor Mechaniacal should also give Professor Quantum some trouble.”

“Especially since he didn’t plant trackers in most of my clothes,” Tori added.

That earned her a look of sharp surprise from Ivan, which she met with a shrug. “Yeah, I noticed. Didn’t have room to complain as an apprentice, and after getting attacked during Balaam’s uprising, I decided that someone being able to find me might not be the worst thing.”

“Except for when those trackers are blocked,” Ivan muttered. “The point is, we’ve got a little bit of time to work in. Maybe a day or two, at most. The question is what do you want to do with that time?”

“Me? Am I supposed to plan my own rescue mission from inside a cell?”

The pacing stopped as Ivan came to a halt not far from where Tori was sitting. Moving with more care than moments before, Ivan took a few steps over, then sank to one knee, putting him at roughly her seated eye level.

“Only a few days ago, I talked to you about figuring out what it means to be a villain for each of us. You hit a crossroads sooner than even I expected, but you’ve still hit one. Given the current predicament, you can deal with this situation as Tori, or as Hephaestus. As Tori, we find where you are and covertly alert the capes. They’ll swoop in, save the day, and send all these people into the court system. That will be what people think happens when you kidnap someone connected to capes off the street.”

“Or, I take the Hephaestus route.” Tori didn’t need the other option explained; it had been burning in the back of her mind since that slap. “But how does that work, exactly? People saw me, Tori Rivas, get captured. If the capes arrive to find an absolute slaughter and me untouched, won’t that raise questions?”

“It would, if you had any way to testify or offer an explanation. We’ve done this before—usually with civilians, but the methodology is still the same. You’ll be in here, locked up, just as the kidnappers left you. All

you'll hear is some noises, maybe a few screams, and then nothing until the capes arrive. No testimony or insights to offer."

Something hard and dark in Tori's heart preened at the image. "Plus, word will get around. The underworld thinks the guild rules no longer apply. That's why they're doing shit this bold. But if the most public kidnapping in years ends with the perpetrators as bloody chunks, that sends a message from the shadows. It reminds them that we're still here, and there are still consequences to stepping over our lines."

"Precisely. We'll leave evidence that it was done by some enemy or rival for the police, while the underworld will hear whispers of the truth. But putting yourself in the center of that could still have consequences down the line. That's why the method we use can only rightly be chosen by the person it impacts the most. You're the one on TV. You're the one who has to live with this either way." Ivan rose from his kneeling position, checking the room once more. "That said, perhaps I should give you some time to think it over. Mind Mirror needs to rest, and it's not like we can act until we know your location. I'll check back in a few hours. If things get rough and you have to kill them, we'll clean up after you."

He tried to put a reassuring hand on her shoulder, but Tori felt nothing. For as real as Ivan looked, he wasn't here. Not yet. "Stay strong, Tori. I promise, I won't make you wait long."

"I'm plenty strong, Ivan. Don't worry about a thing." She met his eyes, staring hard until Ivan seemed convinced.

"When I return, I hope it will be with news. By then, you should have decided which path to take. There may not be time to dawdle."

With a jolt, Tori was out of the vision. Lights were blinking, concrete was unfractured, and the ambient noise of simple existence rushed back into her ears. It was a lot to take in at once, which was why Tori almost didn't notice she had a second visitor until he was through the door.

It was the big one, though he moved with a lot of care as he shut the door behind himself. "Bathroom break. I'm going to uncuff you long enough to do your necessary, then stand with my back to you, facing the door. Feel free to try to attack if you want. It won't work, and we'll stop letting you up to use the toilet, but you should still feel free to try."

Succinct, sincere, and easy to track. This guy knew how to manage a captive. Even his threat was straightforward logic, the sort that balked any

attempts at questioning. It was inaccurate, given that she could in fact hurt him, but he had no way of knowing that.

“Cameras?” Tori asked.

He held up a large finger, then pointed it over to the camera near the front door, the one facing the toilet. Seconds later, the red light died, breaking the cycle of blinking. “Five minutes of privacy.”

“Then you should hurry. That’s not a lot of time to go over whatever secret discussion you wanted to have.” Tori jerked her head in the direction of her back, where she was pulling the handcuffs taut. “I do want that break, though.”

From a pocket, he produced a key that looked comical in his oversized mitts. Using more care than she’d have expected, he unlocked her cuffs, stepping away as Tori gave her wrists a nice long rub. Once that was done, she took mental stock of her bladder, which was mercifully bone dry. The upside to being kidnapped before coffee, she supposed.

“I can skip the porcelain this time. Why don’t we focus on the real reason you’re in here. You know, don’t you? The line your gang is up against, the danger they’re courting.”

“I know rumors. Whispers. Stories and myths about a secret cabal that run the underworld, keeping the capes at bay. I heard about entire gangs vanishing overnight, but that also happens when rivals wipe out their competition. For a long time, I didn’t really believe it. Then one day, I noticed. The higher up I climbed, the more fastidious everyone was about following those whispered rules. Every serious boss and major player treated them like a bible. A few months ago, I found out why. That guild is—was—real. They’re the ones the capes fought during the riots.”

He sat down next to Tori, his augmented size meaning they were roughly on the same shoulder level, despite only one of them having a chair. “What I don’t know is if the rules still apply after the capes raided them. More importantly, it doesn’t explain why *you* seem to know about all of this. The guild is one thing—I think the whole world saw that story. The rules and consequences are another matter. How exactly do you know all of this, Tori Rivas?”

The name was a good touch, something to remind her that he knew who she really was. But it also opened up an opportunity. “That’s not the sort of thing I’d tell a stranger, now is it?”

Warily, he extended his hand. “I go by Darius.”

Tori accepted and shook it. “Nice to meet you, Darius. I’m afraid my explanation isn’t going to be all that satisfying, unfortunately. If you knew my route well enough to snatch me, I’m sure you dug into my available personal history, meaning that you’re probably aware I did a rehab program. Well, you know what comes before rehab.”

Darius did indeed. Working on the streets, he was no stranger to people who’d lost their lives chasing the thrill of a high. “Something bad enough to require you go to rehab.”

“Smart man,” Tori noted. “I was laying low from the cops after a near miss, so I took up space in an abandoned building, probably similar to what you’re all using. Others were using it, too, but beggars, choosers—you know the drill. Except apparently, one group was hiding a kidnapped person. I never knew the details. I only woke up to the aftermath.”

This story was more a chimera of disconnected truths than pure lie. While Tori had never touched a drug stronger than alcohol or caffeine, her pre-guild life included many years living without a home and did feature some dodging of police, as one might expect from a thief. Even the event in question was mostly true, save for the extra group of kidnappers. For this next part, Tori would have to pull from the more recent past: the time Ivan had taken them along to see a code enforcement.

“They don’t leave much. A stain here, a scorch mark there. The parts they do leave—I assume those have to be intentional. So you can fathom what happened to at least a few of them, and your mind can fill in the gaps for the ones reduced to nothing more than fine red mist. I didn’t want to see that, and I think you want to be it even less. Make the right call. Let me go while there’s time.”

For a moment, she thought he was going to listen. Sadly, when Darius rose to his feet, the first thing he did was re-lock Tori into her handcuffs. She didn’t fight or struggle; this wasn’t the time to make a move. At least he didn’t fasten them quite so tightly this time.

“I’m not sure how much of that was true, but I believed enough to worry. The problem is that, even if it’s all completely factual, that still happened before the riots. Before the guild was exposed. Whether or not they can still maintain that control is for the higher-ups to figure out. I’ll raise your concerns to him, though.”

Tori waited until her hands were bound before speaking again. “If you’re wrong, you know you’re killing them, right?”

“Maybe, but I can’t live their lives for them, either,” Darius countered. “I’ll talk to the boss. With what you can prove, I don’t see much changing, though. The guild just isn’t as scary now that it’s out of the shadows.”

Darius left the room, and a few seconds later, the cameras began to blink once more. Once more alone with her thoughts, Tori could no longer find easy respite in dreams of her planned designs. No, thanks to Ivan, she now had a heavy decision resting on her shoulders.

And worse, after talking with Darius, Tori was starting to realize which path the world needed her to take.

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## Chapter 25

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It was hard to be helpless. To see something happen that was *wrong*, yet be unable to do *anything*. Because he was too weak, too afraid, too useless to change the outcome. When Donald Moss embraced his abilities, part of him thought those days were done. No matter the situation, he could help a small bit now, at least in theory. As it turned out, having more power only made that damned sense of helplessness all the more frustrating.

He wanted to be out on the streets with the rest of the capes, looking for clues. Coming back from patrol to find video of his friend being kidnapped off the street was bad enough. Asking to help find her and being sent to a waiting room was all the worse.

A heavy hand rested on Donald's shoulder: Ren, forcing him out of his stewing. The pair were seated in a lush waiting room, tastefully decorated in muted colors, with vintage AHC posters adorning the walls as accents. The images were largely filled with older capes, most of whom were retired now, along with a few newer ones who'd attained some glory. Apollo had probably been up there, before he betrayed them. For his part, Donald kept glancing from the television screen to the poster of Lodestar. It would be okay. They had the most powerful capes in the world on their side. If anyone could help Tori, it was the Alliance of Heroic Champions. Donald just wished they'd get on with it, or let him help.

"Easy, buddy. Save your energy. Whatever they want us for, they're probably just waiting on Irene and Lucy," Ren assured him.

The other half of their team had been needed to help deal with a wildfire earlier that morning— Irene with her ice, and Lucy by summoning a spray

of water from her hat. It was a move that made far more sense before their entire day had been uprooted, but the higher-ups had determined they could do more good there than here, so the work continued.

“Let’s hope not. They could be gone all day. I’m not going to just sit here while god knows what is happening to my friend.” Donald started to rise, then looked again to the poster. So easily, she’d crushed the AHC base’s defenses. What had been a harrowing, near-death experience for his team wasn’t even a blip to Lodestar. Much as he wanted to help Tori, Donald also knew his limits. If the most powerful superheroes in the world couldn’t fly around and stumble onto Tori, then what were his odds?

The issue resolved itself when the lounge doors opened to reveal two more figures. Though he’d yet to meet either, Donald knew them on sight. Given how much attention the media was giving them, it was hard not to recognize Agent Quantum and Tachyonic, especially since both were in full costume. Donald didn’t bother with a mask since his identity was public, which meant he got to keep more casual attire, especially around the base. Usually a perk, at that moment he hated feeling so human.

“What the hell? If anyone should be out there searching for Tori, it should be *you*.” Even Donald was surprised by the heat in his voice. He hadn’t realized he was standing and stalking across the room until he’d gotten a few feet from Tachyonic. “Why aren’t you out there helping?”

“Let me answer your question with a question: who the fuck are you?” Tachyonic shot back, immediately bristling. “Did somebody order a sandwich and you’re the lucky delivery boy taking himself on a tour?”

A flush crept along Donald’s pale skin, like a red tide washing over his freckles. “Yeah, you probably wouldn’t have seen my work. I’m not so desperate for attention that I drag innocent civilians into the spotlight, so I’m clearly not playing on your media level.” It had been a long time since Donald was genuinely pissed off, but the cocktail of fear and guilt were pushing his emotions off-keel, and Tachyonic made for a semi-deserving easy target.

“Cyber Geek, I can see you’re upset. However, right now, it isn’t about who is at fault. It’s about saving the person in danger. Do you think us being at odds helps, or hurts, her chances of a quick recovery?”

They were the first words Agent Quantum had spoken, and they were well chosen. Hearing his superhero name brought Donald up short, reminding him of what really mattered. He was angry, and Tachyonic



deserved some of that, but not the full force. The guy had been a new cape on his first day. He made an honest mistake. Donald had made plenty himself already, with ample more surely waiting down the road. Still, it was hard not to seethe, knowing that however inadvertently, Tachyonic had made Tori a target.

“You’re right,” Donald said at last. “I’m sorry, but I’m also climbing the walls in here. Why are we being shelved when the rest of the AHC is in full swing?”

“Because it was theorized you might be of use.” The voice didn’t belong to anybody Donald had heard in person before, yet he knew it instantly. Anyone who did even a modicum of research into meta-humans would have heard hours and hours of it, as it belonged to premiere expert on the phenomenon that created them. For the first few decades, he was considered the unrivaled authority on all things meta, and even now, his theories and talks were referenced by countless researchers.

Professor Quantum strode into the lounge, Lodestar and Quorum on his heels. He looked the same as he had for as long as Donald had been alive: a tall, serious man with salt-and-pepper at the temples. His physique was substantially sturdier than most men of science, though the full suit, tie, and lab coat did hide all but the most obvious features. Times and styles might change, but Professor Quantum cared as much about such things as he did about the opinions of those who weren’t him, which was to say minimally. While unquestionably the original meta-human and first superhero in known history, he never quite managed to connect with the public on his own. Professor Quantum was respected, admired, and feared, but seldom beloved.

“Theorized by Lodestar, I should add, who seems to think you have similar potential to Mr. AV. Her estimations of your powers appear slightly askew, likely because you were able to breach our barrier with the aid of your items. I am of the opinion that such force was a fluke. However, one can never dismiss a potential option, especially when time is a factor. You are our wild card, representing access to tools not accounted for in technological or magical defenses.”

“We also knew you’d want to take an active role in finding your friend,” Lodestar tacked on, almost as an apology for Professor Quantum. From how seamlessly she slipped in the diplomacy, it was plainly a skill she’d gotten from ample practice.

That revelation did earn him a new look from Tachyonic, though. “Wait, you actually know Tori?”

“We used to work together. Hard not to be friends with someone once you’ve survived weekly meetings and a gang of metas trying to rob your office,” Donald replied. “So I’d really like it if we could get her back, and soon.”

The sound of Quorum messing with the television drew everyone’s attention, as it had been intended to. He cued up a different feed; the television now showed a large map of Ridge City, with a pin dropped at the scene of Tori’s location.

“The van they used to kidnap Tori Rivas appears to be employing whatever tech they’re using to mask her holding location. While we aren’t able to track it with anything except our eyes, Ridge City has enough traffic cameras that we were able to follow their route after the abduction.”

Quorum touched a button on a remote and a new line appeared, showing the van making a direct run for what appeared to be a parking garage a few miles from the kidnapping site. “Unfortunately, our intel cuts out here. The van is no longer in the garage, meaning they either utilized teleportation or illusions to get out, and from that point on, we can no longer follow their route. Since they drove right to it, they clearly weren’t worried about us discovering the location, making the odds of discovering a hidden route or tunnel minimal. We do have resources checking, just to be sure.”

“Ordinarily, the solution here would be a simple one,” Professor Quantum interrupted. “Once tracking is thwarted, magic becomes the most expedient solution. We have several assets on staff capable of casting a finding spell, none of whom have succeeded. We are unable to follow or find the van, to say nothing of the woman inside, by either technological or mystical means. This means someone came to this operation prepared, and has forced us to think outside the box.”

“What about a psychic?” Ren asked. “I’ve chatted with Afterthought enough to know that not all mystical wards work on them. Even if she can’t do it, there’s Headspace, the woman she’s been learning from.”

It was Lodestar who fielded this one. “Psychics are wonderful helpers in the right situations. However, making a connection in these sorts of circumstances would be extremely difficult. I already asked some to reach out, and the general consensus seems to be that while a few can feel her

mind's presence, none can connect with it. The only way to have a real shot would be with someone she's close to. Family close, I mean."

Donald couldn't have asked for a more tactful way to be told his connection wasn't enough, even if it didn't make the message any better to hear.

"Hence why you are here." Professor Quantum stepped forward until he loomed over Donald, tapping the younger cape just above his eyebrow. "Thus far, your new system has met every metric and safety test they've insisted on imposing, with nary a single glitch or hiccup. Time to start earning that upgrade. You've got a curious assortment of toys at your fingertips, Mr. Moss. Anything in there that might help us find Miss Rivas?"

One upside to his earlier flush with fury was that Donald was already too red for anyone to notice the tinge of embarrassment that was being added to it. He wished one of the AHC's founding members hadn't just referred to his entire power as "toys," but it was hard to find a counterargument, especially given the more pressing concerns. The best rebuttal, he realized, would be to actually have something that helped.

"Give me a moment. I'll check." Closing his eyes wasn't necessary, but it did make the screen easier to see. As the world went dark, Donald pulled up his item selection screen. The "upgrade," as Professor Quantum put it, had actually been an involved surgery with some serious risk, one that Donald considered well worth it.

Gone was his old wrist unit, where he had to clumsily slap about for items. Now, the entire computer was housed in a series of tiny connected units throughout his skull. An optical inlay projected the display into his vision, allowing Cyber Geek to seemingly pull the items from thin air. In reality, he was still yanking them out of a computer, it was just a computer no one else could see.

Control had been the hardest issue. There was a wireless connection option for playing and leveling his games to improve the items, but working the actual screen in the field required Donald to do it himself. The system had been wired to his nervous system, like attaching a new artificial limb, and over time, he'd gained enough skill to cycle through his options on the fly. It still took time, especially under stress, but every day he worked to get better at it. This was a gift, and he knew that, the sort of augmentation only one of the world's greatest minds could offer.

Determined to both save Tori and prove himself worth the effort, Donald ran through his options. Almost everything he'd been working on was combat based, tools to keep civilians safe or to neutralize villains, with only a smattering of utility options like the *Jump Jump Jones* boot rounding things out. He had to keep thinking. Donald was more than just the options on the screen. He was also the sum of his own knowledge. The tool he needed wasn't in his arsenal yet, but he knew where to get it.

"There's a game called *Constable Fluffers*, indie title from a few years back. Basically, a mix of mystery and team building, where you get magic items that help you find clues and solve cases. One of the final pieces in the game is a magnifying glass that reveals the general area of what you're looking for on a map. I'll need to get it loaded and leveled first; that's going to take a while."

"That would be useful, both in today's situation and in future predicaments, assuming it works." Professor Quantum nodded stiffly, but approval was approval. "Your friend there is relieved of patrol duty in order to assist you with whatever you need. Do try to hurry, if you can. While Miss Rivas presumably had nothing of use to share, they will no doubt still be trying to extract information about the AHC from her. I suspect the sooner we arrive, the better."

If Donald had been motivated before, those words nearly had him tearing out of the room in a dead sprint. Before he had the chance, Agent Quantum stepped forward. It was only then that Donald realized Professor Quantum hadn't so much as looked at his namesake since entering the room.

"Sir, I submitted a report over the weekend, but it should be noted that Tori Rivas *does* have some information about the AHC. Specifically, my team was forced to out themselves in covering for my error. She knows who the New Science Sentries are."

Slowly, Professor Quantum's eyes closed, like he was fighting off a headache. "We'll deal with the consequences of that once the young lady is rescued. For now, try to stay out of trouble, Version Nineteen. You two were called here to see if you could offer any insight, but I believe that's no longer needed. Go get assignments with the rest of the masses."

A long pause stretched out in the room, wandering around and making itself at home before Agent Quantum scared it off with a stiff reply. "Yes, sir." He took Tachyonic's arm and both of them left quickly, though

Tachyonic looked like he was trying to keep a live squirrel in his mouth with how hard he was biting down.

Professor Quantum didn't even wait until they were gone to look back over at Donald.

"As for you, get to work. Report to the Champions' Congress office when you're ready." He glanced up and noticed Ren was still there. "You, help him as needed. This is top priority, all the more so now that we know AHC secrets are up for grabs."

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## Chapter 26

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“Fuck him!” Kyle was fuming, stalking around the empty breakroom like he was trying to slowly build up speed. Thankfully, with most of the AHC active, they more or less had a whole floor to themselves. “That’s not all right. It was *never* all right, and now, he’s calling you that in front of other superheroes? He’s such a piece of shit.”

“The piece of shit who’s responsible for us all having powers, training, and this very team,” Austin replied. How he managed to stay so calm in such moments was a talent Kyle had never grasped. “Along with me existing in the first place.”

“That doesn’t give him the right to treat you like one of his inventions.”

“Kyle, a woman is kidnapped because of mistakes our team made. My feelings are not the most pressing matter before us.”

The sound of footsteps from behind surprised both men; they hadn’t heard so much as a whisper coming down the hall. As they both whipped around, it became obvious why. Lodestar was standing in the doorway, settling onto her toes after having mostly floated her way down. It was impossible to say how long she’d been there; Lodestar’s speed was largely determined by how fast she felt like going in that particular moment.

“Couldn’t have said it better myself.” Lodestar walked to the plain white fridge and yanked it open, pulling out a frozen, premade coffee drink that relied as much on sugar as actual caffeine to create a buzz. “Still, urgent as things are, you have to conserve your energy. Burning yourself out worrying might feel good in the moment, but when the time for action does come, don’t you want to go in at full strength?”

In a blur, Kyle wheeled on her. “I’m sorry we can’t just sit back and chill while our fuck up is probably getting someone tortured!”

Both men’s eyes went wide as the words echoed through the breakroom. Lipping off to one of the highest-ranking members of the AHC was perhaps not the wisest of moves, all the more so considering how much less she deserved it than Professor Quantum.

To both their surprise, Lodestar’s reaction was to set down her drink, reach forward, and carefully take Kyle by the shoulders.

“Hey. Look at me. It’s *okay*. It’s not your fault. I know what you’re feeling right now. That burning in your stomach, stretching out into your veins and skin, all the way up to your brain. I’ve carried that same guilt with me so many times, knowing that something I did, sometimes not even a mistake, might get someone innocent hurt. But you can’t lay it all at your own feet. You made an error in the field, and you’ve been working to correct it. Don’t go down the path of putting their crimes on yourself. Feeling guilty doesn’t actually fix anything. You have to push past it and get to work if you want to put things right.”

She pulled him in closer, hugging the younger cape gently. “It’s going to be okay.”

“How can you be so sure?” Kyle slowly pulled out of the hug, his anger effectively disarmed. Growing up on the island, kindness and understanding were not tactics he was used to encountering when mistakes were made.

“Because we’re superheroes. We save the day. We’re going to *make* it be okay.”

For an instant, despite the intermittent floating and glow along her skin, Austin had nearly forgotten he was watching Lodestar herself. In that moment, when he saw the glint of determination in her eyes, a chill ran down his spine. Different as she was from what he might have expected, there was no ignoring her track record. Every major threat to the world that had dared step up to her had gotten knocked down. She’d even changed the way humanity fought wars with one display of her true power. The only reason her fights lasted longer than nanoseconds was that Lodestar clearly preferred to work with kid gloves, only trotting out her real strength for deserving foes.

“And I wouldn’t imagine the worst for Tori just yet,” she continued. “The kidnappers were careful not to use excessive force during the extraction, so they seem to be playing this smart. It’s unlikely they’ll go to

torture right off the bat, anyway; people tend to overestimate their stomach for it. Besides, Donald seems to think she's a tough cookie. Let's put more energy into finding her than worrying about what we'll discover upon arrival."

It didn't exactly set their whole world right, but Kyle no longer seemed inclined to pace the room, which was a marked improvement. Austin realized that he felt a little better, as well. Having someone in charge was a relief. Hard as he'd trained to be team leader, situations like this remained out of his depth. They still had a responsibility to try their best, but it was easier to move without the full weight of the world on his shoulders.

"When you two are ready, I'm heading down. With things this stirred up, going out in force reminds criminals that just because we've got something on our plate doesn't mean we're too busy to protect the world. A full press works better with more bodies, so if you're up for it, come on out with me."

"Professor Quantum ordered us to stay out the way and stick with the masses," Austin replied.

"Guess that means you'd better be more help than hindrance," she shot back. "This *is* the masses. I'm leading the next shift out onto patrol."

That drew a sharp cough from Kyle, who'd been trying to sip some water and calm down. "Leading patrol? You're one of the heads of the Champions' Congress. Why are you taking patrol?"

"Let's just say Professor Quantum and I have different leadership styles." In a practiced motion, Lodestar downed the entirety of her coffee drink, then dropped the glass bottle into the recycling bin. "Doesn't actually do anything for me, but darned if I don't love the taste. So, you want to keep wallowing up here, or go do some good?"

Both men had slipped their masks back on before the question was done being asked. Lodestar led Tachyonic and Agent Quantum down to where the others were waiting. It was time to make sure the world remembered why the wicked ran when the Alliance of Heroic Champions came to call.



Augustus Glynis was a man who liked habits. Same breakfast, same office, same routes. People thought patterns made them predictable, but Augustus



knew his terrain perfectly. One blade of grass out of place, and he was on guard. It was easier to catch a rat when one left them nowhere to hide.

Tonight, he climbed the stairs into his private office, stepped through the door, and instantly knew something was wrong. There were many giveaways: the angle of his chair, the positioning of the doorknob, the slight scent of metal, and beyond them all, the heat. A roaring fire at the tail end of summer was certainly not common practice.

Of course, it also helped that his intruder was seated next to his fireplace, helping herself to a sizable glass of very expensive bourbon. For the briefest of moments, he considered calling for security, but then his eyes focused. This wasn't some two-bit bot cobbled together by an angry tinkerer looking to make a name. She was sleek, powerful, and unmistakable, at least to those in Augustus's field. Learning to recognize the guild's more aggressive players was a basic survival skill for anyone who wanted to amass power in the underworld.

"Xelas, I'm surprised to see you in Detroit. To what do I owe the unannounced pleasure?"

"Unannounced? You wound me, Augustus. When you killed the last boss and annexed his territory, we graciously took the time to come out and explain how things worked. I like to think of this as a working relationship, the sort that would welcome drop-ins."

"Perhaps I just suspected you'd be off making better use of the opportunity. After all, with the capes in a lather over that missing girl, the rest of us have far more room to work in." He made his way over to the desk. Inside was a gun, as well as an experimental photon pistol he'd picked up some years back. It had a lot of stopping power; whether or not it would be enough to wound Xelas was a crapshoot. Best to save it for a last resort.

How she managed to make a "tsk" sound without opening her mouth, he had no idea, yet it still resounded through the office. "You're a world-class dipshit if you pull anything major tonight. Capes being whipped up makes them faster to react, not slower. They know what you're thinking. But the capes aren't the issue for us this evening. I'm here to talk about Lowendale Court Apartments."

The plasma gun in his desk suddenly seemed far more appealing than it had moments prior, yet Augustus resisted the urge to reach for it. If she wanted to kill him, the preamble was unnecessary. Things might not be lost quite yet.

“You broke a few of our terms getting those built, though admittedly minor ones, and you’ve been using shell companies to make it look like you don’t own them, keeping the revenue off the books. *Our* revenue, I should say. Did you forget your tithe, Augustus? Did you forget that keeping us out of your hair means obeying the rules and paying the bill? Did you think we didn’t notice? Let me assure you, such was not the case. We’ve known since day one what you were doing.”

“Then you certainly took your sweet time in calling me on it.” Augustus looked across the room from his seat to the red upholstered chair Xelas was sitting in. The color was no coincidence, nor was the fact that it matched the carpet that ran across most of the wooden floors. Shades chosen to hide blood, just in case covert transportation was required. None of which mattered when dealing with a mechanical opponent.

“It would be more apt to say we waited until there was a substantial need,” Xelas corrected. “Lots of you little fish think you can get away with something; smacking you around for every tiny infraction is a waste of our time. But when we need a favor, it helps to have leverage. Because we *do* play by our own rules. We honor what we say. If you’d been a good boy, I’d be bothering someone else right now. Keep that in mind: you’re the one who did this.”

Clear as the threat was, Augustus also felt a sliver of relief. She wanted something. That was the opening of negotiations, negotiations that could potentially end with him alive. As Xelas herself had just said, the guild kept its word. Getting her to agree to spare him would actually be a reasonable guarantee of safety.

“I’m guessing you don’t want the money.”

“Look at you, quick on the draw.” Xelas winked, a gesture that almost made him inadvertently reach for the drawer. “To tell you the truth, we don’t even need the money in the first place. It’s more about reminding you all that there’s someone higher up the food chain. But since you didn’t pay your tab, the cost is going to be substantially higher. We’re going to need information, cooperation, and corpses. The corpses of your men.”

There was a lot to sort through in that demand; however, Augustus was no timid newbie. He looked his age—and then some—thanks to the stress of keeping this enterprise afoot in a world of meddling superheroes and intruding villains. The first things to get nailed down, especially in situations like these, were the specifics.

“How many corpses?”

“Between four and eight should do it. Enough to look like you made an assault against some interlopers in your territory and lost a few in the process. The upside is, your organization will get official blame for the public slaughter we leave behind. Even with whispers of the truth floating around, that should buy you some clout on the streets for a while. Plus, if you want to use this chance to unload some dead weight or potential turncoats, feel free.”

She punctuated the statement by finishing off the last of the bourbon and carefully setting the glass down on a side table. “I can handle the killing myself, if you need. All you have to do is get them to the right place at the right time.”

“Do I even get to know what this is all about?” Augustus asked.

“If you really want to, but I’d caution against it. The more you know, the more dangerous things get. What concerns you is that someone pissed us off, and they’re in your town. Finding them will be part of the package, but the biggest piece of the equation is helping us with the cover story.”

“For the sake of curiosity, let’s say I refuse.”

Xelas rose from the chair slowly, making certain not to seem like she was attacking just yet. Between the flames, the chair, and the rug, her metal body almost seemed to be glowing red. “You fucked some people up to get the permits on that building through. One of those adjusters you beat never recovered full use of his legs, to say nothing of the medical bills they grappled with. That’s just this one project—I know your whole history. Even if I were an especially moral person, I’d feel no compunctions about slaughtering your entire enterprise.”

“The heartless robot sent to intimidate the fragile humans. For one with your history, I never expected you to willingly choose servitude.” Pushing Xelas off-balance was a risky move, but as things stood, Augustus had little chance for anything else. Perhaps, if he could distract her, enrage her, there might be a moment of opportunity.

To his surprise, his vicious words were greeted with a smile. “People always think that, but it’s not that I’m heartless, or even especially brutal. It’s just... let me put it this way, did you ever take apart something electronic, maybe a toaster? To fix it, to break it, just to see how it works?”

Slowly, Augustus nodded. Lying seemed the fastest way to a sure death; better to see where she was taking this.

“Don’t worry. I’m not going to take revenge for you taking apart a non-sentient piece of machinery any more than you’d be mad at someone for dissecting a frog. Just because you’re both biological doesn’t mean you see yourselves as the same. My point is, when you took that toaster apart, did you feel anything?”

She was closer now, standing before his desk, nearly within arm’s reach. “Did you feel disgust, or sympathy, or wonder for even a moment how the toaster felt?”

“Of course not,” Augustus said.

“Of course not,” Xelas agreed. “Because to you, it’s just a mess of odds and ends, not the sort of materials you associate with a living being. Which is perfectly natural, Augustus. You don’t need to feel bad about it at all.”

Another smile, only now, it wasn’t nearly so friendly, with the flickering flames reflected in her shiny skin. “But by the same token, you couldn’t expect the toaster to feel anything if the roles were reversed. To that toaster, you’d be nothing more than a sack of red pulp and white sticks. It’s amazing the sorts of damage you can do to a thing when you feel *no* empathy for its pain. Now, are you going to draw that shitty little photon gun I left in your drawer, or do you want to start making some calls?”

Hand shaking, Augustus reached for the phone.

As he did, Xelas watched, still smiling. “Go ahead and pour me another glass of that good stuff. Need to keep the throat from getting parched while I walk you through the rest of the details.”

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## Chapter 27

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“They posted demands.”

Ivan turned to find Wade standing in the door, phone held up to display a news story. With a click of a button, the image transferred onto the meeting room’s screen: an anchor desk and several images of the publicly released demands. It was the first communication from the kidnappers since Tori had been taken, and Ivan read each word painstakingly.

The demands weren’t especially complex. It was a gauntlet-throw: the gang was calling out the New Science Sentries. They were to arrive at noon the following day to a location that would be revealed soon, alone. Any other capes in attendance would lead to the hostage being killed—or at least, that was their claim. Ivan had his doubts that Tori would go along with that option, though ideally, he’d prefer she not have to fight her way out single-handedly. The whole thing might have had Ivan feeling nostalgic, if he weren’t so angry.

“A call-out? All this for a damn call-out? Those miserable wretches stole a civilian off the streets and stirred up the entire AHC in order to have a grudge match with a team that’s barely even a week old?” Ivan pressed his hands against one another. He’d learned a long time ago that one of the few things he could hold with any real force was himself, a helpful trick in times of stress. “It makes no sense. Someone with the equipment to foil both the guild and the AHC using it like this...”

“It’s a beta-test,” Wade interrupted. “Someone is using a gang with more ambition than sense to see how their equipment holds up. I’m not sure if they knew Tori was with us, or if this was purely targeted at the AHC. My

hunch is the latter, mostly because the few enemies both organizations shared were world-ending threats that have been dealt with.”

Now *that*, Ivan could wrap his head around. “Enflame the AHC publicly so they have to respond, all in order to make sure the system is being tested against the best they can offer. See how long it takes for them to crack through, and figure out how they do it to develop countermeasures. The girl and the gang don’t actually matter; they’re just a setting for the experiment.”

On screen, the anchor vanished, replaced by a map of Detroit. It was impossible to miss the Guardian’s Tower, a massive memorial commemorating those who’d died during the Korot Spider outbreak in the sixties. They’d managed to kill the hive queen, but not without terrible losses, and the city had chosen to honor them for their sacrifice. Most cities had some sort of feature like the Guardian’s Tower, in truth. The world had been a scarier place, before it gained a nigh invulnerable last line of defense.

“We’ve found her general area, and Xelas made contact with the locals to get the ball moving on her end. I predict that before the night’s end, we’ll have Tori’s location and some bodies to leave behind as a misdirect. Do you think she’ll give the order, or let the capes deal with it?” Wade didn’t seem especially concerned either way. He was asking with the same academic curiosity he addressed most subjects. A lot of people took that to mean that Wade didn’t care, but Ivan knew better. Wade was simply the kind of man who functioned best when calm, and he preferred to be at the top of his game as often as possible. Especially in a crisis.

For his part, Ivan didn’t have an answer at the ready. “It’s hard to say. Tori wants to stay out of the spotlight, and going our route will put more attention on her. At the same time, she understands what this guild does, and why it’s needed. She knows that if these sorts of kidnappings become commonplace again, there’s no predicting the fallout. Today, it was a capable member of the guild who can handle herself. The next one snatched probably won’t be so lucky. Besides...”

Ivan looked down at his hands. They were clean tonight, not so much as a speck of blood. He could still see it, though. Still feel it, smell it—taste it, if he wasn’t careful. “Tori has a hole in her where her parents and childhood are supposed to be. She’s filled it with anger because that was the only fuel that would keep her moving, and while she’s grown tremendously since

trying to rob us, that fury is layered in deep. Most people couldn't order the execution of an entire gang, not even in her situation. But people with that chunk of themselves missing... well, we're another story."

"I thought so, too," Wade agreed. "Pity we can't bring the armor and let her participate. Then again, I suppose there's no rush to add to these kids' kill counts. I'll stick to those more comfortable with getting their hands dirty."

"You should consider bringing her armor anyway." Ivan wasn't sure where the unsettled feeling in his gut was coming from, only that he trusted it. "Something's off about this whole fiasco. I think you've got the right idea on what's really happening, but whoever our opponent is, they've been exceedingly competent so far. Let's not fall into the cape habit of presuming ourselves better than our enemies. Be ready for more surprises."

Wade glanced down at his watch, checking the time. "I could send someone over to access her lab; if Bahamut is there, she can help get things loaded." A pause, as Wade further considered Ivan's words. "In fact, let's have Bahamut just bring it over herself. You make a good point. This is an official guild operation. We'll risk over-preparing rather than go in under. I'll put Bahamut, Pest Control, and Glyph into a rescue team. If anything goes wrong, they'll be tasked with extricating Tori while the rest of the responders do the bloody work."

Despite the fact that it had technically been his suggestion that led to the idea, Ivan wasn't sure how he felt about that plan. "Aren't they a little young to risk bringing to that violent of a scene? We've already made them watch one code enforcement."

"They won't be young forever. One day, they'll be the ones making these calls, so I'd like them to start building experience in the hopes they'll make the right ones. Would you rather they have their first extraction with us around to watch their backs, or wait until they *have* to do it because everyone else is out of commission?"

That was the trouble with arguing against one of the world's greatest minds; Wade could make everything he did sound completely logical. On this account, he had a valid point. Neither man planned to run this guild forever. The more they could teach the ones coming up behind them, the more competent the hands that would one day steer the organization. That didn't mean they had to be reckless about it, however.

“I’ll take that team in, if it’s needed,” Ivan said. “Just in case they run into any hidden surprises, I should be more than enough to ensure they make it through unscathed.”

“Some thought you’d want to be leading the slaughter.” On his phone, Wade punched in a few inputs. “Glad to see my way of thinking was correct. You were already slated to be in charge of that group, and I just sent through the confirmation.”

Another night, Ivan might have been genuinely annoyed by being called predictable, but given the day’s events, the most he could manage was mild curiosity. “How’d you know I’d go that route?”

“Because I know *you*, Ivan. When pushed, you’ll always put the few things you care about first. No matter how many corpses you might create in the process.” Wade hit a few more buttons, then read something on his phone’s screen. “Estimates say we could have a location on Tori by dawn. Get some rest if you need it, but be down with Mind Mirror an hour before sunrise. Once we know where she is, Tori will have to make her choice.”

There was no chance Ivan would be sleeping that night, yet he did force himself to calm down. Rest would be good. Centering himself, getting mentally prepared, those were better uses of his time than pointless worrying. When the time to rescue Tori came, Ivan intended to be at the top of his game. Much to the misfortune of any poor piece of shit that got between him and his former apprentice.



Hearing the door unlock, Tori expected to see Darius step through. So far, he’d been her only visitor, releasing her hands for three bathroom breaks and one short meal. Conversation had hit a dead end, unfortunately, as no amount of prodding would get Darius past a general sense of worry. He didn’t believe in the threat enough to force action—a thing Tori was trying hard not to dwell on. She wasn’t a fan of where that realization had led for her impending decision. The more she saw them ignoring guild rules, the harder it was to deny the need for a concrete lesson.

As it turned out, she was partially right. Darius indeed came through, only with him was the leader and the reptile-looking guy.



Her broken-nosed abductor walked right up to Tori, plainly intent on taking control this time. “Good evening. Maybe morning by now—who can keep track? Since the hour is late, and you’re no doubt exhausted, this seemed a good time to get to know one another better.”

Interrogating someone while they were tired wasn’t a bad move; it was just this guy’s misfortune that he’d chosen a prisoner used to pulling back-to-back all-nighters. True, Tori would have killed, almost literally, for an espresso in that moment, but she was nowhere near the point of true exhaustion.

“Sure. Let’s do you first. I’m guessing you come from some two-dog, who-gives-a-fuck town, where you had a minor meta-advantage over the humans. You became the lord of Shitdelphia, bought into your own hype, and tried to take your show on the road to the big city. Only to discover that, oh no, your half-baked criminal mastermind crap doesn’t cut it in the real world. Now, you’re just scrambling to hang on to what little power you’ve got before everyone realizes the emperor has no clothes.”

Unlike last time, he took the verbal assault in its entirety. Some time to compose himself had evidently done the kidnapper quite a bit of good, as he was barely even ruffled by the end of the tirade. “Such colorful language. You should work on that, if you expect to be taken seriously.”

“Suck my dick,” Tori shot back, earning herself a look of confusion from the snake-guy. “It’s metaphorical. And it’s *huge*.”

“Ignore her, Emory. Miss Rivas is talking tough because it’s all she can do, and she’s scared.” Her kidnapper leaned in closer, enough that she could almost taste the red-stained gauze covering his nose. “With her arms tied, she’s only bravado and curse words. Her courage will soon—FUCK!”

Since the kidnapper had been kind enough to get close, Tori took the opportunity to quickly rock her neck back and then jerk it forward, slamming her skull directly into the already broken nose. He reeled back, hand going to cover the fresh font of blood bursting forth. At his side, the snake-guy—Emory, he’d been called—yanked out an already blood-coated towel.

“Hang on, Deacon. Let me get pressure on it.”

At least Tori now had a name for her captor, although Deacon seemed less pleased than she was with this turn of events. That composure he’d come in with was already slipping as he leapt to his feet, stalking over to her and glowering down, trying to use his height to scare her while also

keeping a safe distance, which rather undermined the already pathetic intimidation.

“What the hell is wrong with you? I have given you every chance to cooperate, to be a model prisoner, and yet you do nothing but make trouble. Is force really the only thing that you’ll respond to?”

“Oh, if you try force, you’ll definitely find a response waiting.” Tori grinned up at him, a wider smile than she’d ever actually sport—but just like at the office, this was about putting on a show. “Let me break this down for you, Deacon. Whatever you think you’re doing, you have no concept of how deeply fucked you are. Do you know why no one uses hostages to go for capes? Because it doesn’t work. At best—absolute best—they show up and throw you all in jail. More likely, the capes arrive to find you all in puddles and pieces.”

“Yes, yes, I’ve heard the rumors, as well as the lies you fed my bodyguard.” Deacon leaned in closer, though not so close as before. He was capable of learning, if nothing else. “Now, let me give you an ultimatum. The next time I come in here, you’re going to tell me everything you know about the New Science Sentries, and you’re going to be a good, placid little hostage. We know more than just your name, after all. Maybe you’d like us to scoop up one of your roommates for company. I doubt both of them have your same resolve.”

That was where a world without limits would lead, plain and simple, laid out before Tori’s eyes. If they couldn’t beat their true enemy—be it a troublesome prisoner or a legendary cape—they’d go after the target’s allies. Beverly would be fine, and Chloe’s power was unpredictably dangerous, but that wouldn’t be true for every case. This wasn’t even something connected to the guild. It could just as easily have been a normal human sitting in this room, hearing these threats.

Whatever optimism Tori had for finding another way out died as she looked into Deacon’s eyes. Capes gave the world hope, yet that wasn’t enough. The world also needed fear. The darkest parts, where the light couldn’t reach, would obey terror where decency fell short. They had to know there were consequences to stepping outside the rules. It wasn’t society’s law they should fear, it was the guild’s code. *Her* code, because she was one of them. After tonight, that would be truer than ever before.

“Darius, you’ve been a pretty decent guy throughout all of this. If there’s anyone here you care about, evacuate both them and yourself soon.

When the shadows come, they won't be making exceptions." Though the words were for Darius, she leveled Deacon with her gaze. "As for you, oh great and terrible leader, feel free to crawl back in here and beg for your life once your entire crew is slaughtered. Seems like the way a coward like you should die, does it not? Groveling in his shit-filled slacks."

"Let me assure you, on the off chance your little prediction did come true, the only reason I'd be coming in here would be to kill you myself," Deacon shot back.

"Promise? Don't threaten me with a party and then stand a girl up."

Deacon gave her another pointed stare before the dripping from his nose required attention once more. He motioned for the bodyguards to follow, Emory going first, Darius in the rear to lock the door behind them. As he closed it, the big meta looked right at Tori, uncertainty looming wide in his eyes.

"I'm serious. Go. *Now*. After what your boss just said, there's no other way out."

The door closed in place, leaving behind a Tori who was far less conflicted than she'd been moments before. Unfortunately, conviction didn't help the churn in her stomach as she pictured all those dead bodies. It didn't matter, though. The standard had to be set. For the civilians, for her friends, for the world in general. Those rules, that code, it kept everyone safer, whether they knew it or not.

People needed to remember what happened to those who crossed the guild, and some messages could only be delivered in blood.

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## Chapter 28

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The huge man in a leather jacket reared back, ready to slam the stop sign he'd torn from the ground through the brightly-masked head of a cape. He swung with everything he had, only to feel the entire thing come to a halt inches from contact. The searing glow gave it away an instant before Lodestar used her grip on the sign to pop him in the head with his own weapon. The blow merely knocked him unconscious, sending him collapsing to the ground rather than dead.

"Flame Fist, keep your eyes on a swivel. A battleground is an ever-shifting entity. What you knew two seconds ago is already old news. Nice kick on the guy with pipes, by the way."

Then she was gone, zipping over to another part of the battlefield, stopping some other crook from landing a serious blow on one of the capes. Not many people could see what she was doing, the way she was controlling the entire fight. Searstream, however, was part of the aerial team for this fight. Between his willful disregard for gravity and the potent blasts capable of firing from his hands, Searstream was largely picking off targets engaged with other capes in melee, making himself as useful as possible.

Seeing Lodestar run the entire show was an unexpected benefit to pitching in. This was insane, really. What they'd arrived upon was a meta-brawl between Chicago gangs. From what little he'd pieced together in the reports, Searstream knew only that one of them had tried to make a violent push for more territory while the capes were supposed to be busy, and the whole thing had spun out of control. It was violent, dangerous, and in any other situation, he'd have felt like this was getting in too deep for the mass

of largely rookie superheroes who had been called in. But being up here, Searstream understood. They weren't at any risk whatsoever.

Lodestar had turned a horrible situation into both a teaching opportunity and a reminder to everyone out there of what happened to those who disregarded the AHC. TV cameras were sending images of the fight—if one could even call it that—across the world: dozens of gang members going down, and the AHC hadn't taken so much as a scratch. While much of that was due to Lodestar's protection, the other capes were proving that their months of effort hadn't been for naught. Tachyonic was zipping around, aided by shots from Bloopston's water cannon, slapping a pair of cuffs on the criminals most recently taken down by Agent Quantum.

A woman with glowing eyes was moving up on Bloopston, Searstream noticed. He took careful aim, zooming in with the screen and camera system outfitted to his flying goggles, and fired a shot intended to stun without risking lethal damage.

Unfortunately, she turned out to be tougher than her appearance let on. Her eyes glowed brighter as they turned upward, searching the sky. Too bad for her; she didn't hear Lodestar's advice about watching a battlefield. Agent Quantum caught her from behind, pointing her eyes downward just before the beam appeared. Given the way it was eroding the concrete, Searstream was glad not to have taken that one.

A blur of golden light zipped past, and the eye-woman was unconscious. Agent Quantum set her down, giving a short wave to the sky. Not knowing if the other cape could even see him, Searstream waved weakly back, sweeping the battlefield for more targets.

They were in short supply. This fight, like the others tonight, had been short-lived. Get in, get the situation handled safely, evacuate civilians, and move on. True, Lodestar could have ended the fights in seconds herself, but that wasn't the point of the evening. As much as this was about the AHC showing the world that they could still keep it safe, it also appeared to be about teaching the newer capes how to handle fights like these.

"Hey, everyone!" Lodestar's brisk, clear voice rang through their comms. "Headquarters just called, looks like we've got some metas in Connecticut trying to assault a jail and spring their buddy. Find your teleporter and get over there now. I'll go ahead to protect the staff."

A flash of light, and she was gone. Searstream scanned the area on through his goggles, no longer looking for targets. This time, he was

hunting for the hooded woman he'd been assigned to teleport with. This many capes required more than one method of transportation. That was the nice thing about working for the AHC; they'd been at this so long that it was a polished machine. Issues Searstream would have never considered were already planned for well in advance. Between that and having legends like Lodestar and Professor Quantum, Searstream wondered why anyone chose a life of crime knowing the AHC was out there, ready to stop them.



When the world began to crack this time, Tori was ready. She forced herself to relax, mentally searching for Ivan's presence. It made the process go much faster. A break in reality, showing that star-filled void, appeared in seconds, with Ivan soon hustling through like he hadn't quite been ready.

"You have to do it." These were the first words out of her mouth by necessity. Much as she understood why this had to happen, the long-reaching effects it would have and the idea of ordering the elimination of an entire group of people still ate at her. Part of Tori feared that if her words weren't her decision, she would falter and defer to the capes. "We have to send the message that the guild is still here. That the rules still apply."

No judgment from Ivan, not that he'd have much room to throw stones. He accepted the words with a nod, then made his way over to her side. "Are you sure? The capes won't be long now. By noon, I expect they'd have you."

"Good for me. Not so good for the next person some crooks snatch." She tried to scratch her face, remembering for the umpteenth time that her hands were chained. "For me, this has been frustrating, annoying, inconvenient, and only occasionally scary. If I were a normal human... this is the sort of thing that traumatizes people. Besides, the ringleader here threatened my friends. If anyone deserves to be made an example of, it's him."

A moment of hesitation, then Tori continued. "There is one guy who was nice to me during this. Big fellow, named Darius, seemed to have his head more on his shoulders than the rest. He at least clocked the danger in what they were doing, even if he didn't buy the rumors. I can take a reasonable guess on how this will go, and if there's no survivors, then that's

the choice I made. But if there's any wiggle room, Darius probably doesn't deserve to die."

"Your suspicions are no doubt spot on. That said, the guild recognizes that allies can come from unlikely sources. I'll pass the word along. No promises—these things are chaotic by nature—but you've given him a chance. Luck and Darius himself will decide his path from here."

Ivan hunkered down next to Tori, not truly here, yet so real, she'd have tried to pluck an eyelash if her hands were free. "Let's focus on your part now. Ideally, you'll stay right where you are, hear only the barest of sounds through the door, and be discovered by the capes with no story to tell. Less ideally, things go awry and you have to evacuate. Bahamut, Glyph, and Pest Control will be on hand with me and your armor. On the off chance that things get truly out of hand, it's best people see Hephaestus escaping with known villains rather than Tori."

Her nose wrinkled; something smelled off. "Ivan, tech aside, these people are a rinky-dink crew that could barely pull off a bank heist. Why are you talking like they're going to pull out some secret weapon that can knock the fucking *guild* for a loop? It took Apollo using most of the AHC's forces to manage that."

"True or not, they have access to incredibly high-level concealment technology. Given that they called out a team of capes, we have to assume they've got some offensive gear on that same level. It's only prudent."

After what Tori had watched Fornax do when Ivan let loose, she wasn't quite sure what level of tech would be necessary to stop him, but she was fairly sure these mooks didn't have it. Then again, not everyone in the guild was Fornax, or even Pseudonym, so she supposed a bit of circumspection might be in order. Especially if Ivan was stuck babysitting the newbies.

"Do we need to work out our story ahead of time?"

"Not really a story to give, so long as you tell the truth," Ivan replied. "You were stuck in a room, unable to move, until the AHC arrived to free you. If you heard a strange noise around dawn, what of it? You've got no context for the sound, and no known ability or need to help them, even if you did."

Tori looked around, examining the fractured space they were once more in. "Let me guess: if I mention this part at all, I just say I had some weird dreams."

“I’d avoid it entirely, but that’s up to you. My point is you’ll be able to tell the truth and walk out of here without issue. The key is in how much truth you tell.” Ivan stood from his kneeled position, moving to brush off his slacks, only to realize he wasn’t actually there to get dirt on them.

“But that also means we can’t loop you in on anything. If all goes well, you’ll never see or hear us. Once the AHC releases you, we can fill you in on what happened.” Something unusual flickered in Ivan’s face. Fear? Shame? Tori couldn’t tell. She just knew it was an expression she’d seldom even seen hints of. “One more thing to keep in mind: while, officially, Ivan and Fornax have only the slenderest connection in the form of sealed paperwork stored in a government vault, some of the AHC’s higher-ups would know my real identity, since they were around to battle Fornax. If you deal with anyone on the Champions’ Congress, stick to the plan, but be aware that they might know the truth about you.”

Tori’s eyes went wide. “Wait, what? That feels like a pretty damn essential detail to fill me in on. How does that not fuck the entire plan?”

“Because what they know personally and what they can prove in a court of law are different things,” Ivan reminded her. “Just don’t go offering more than you intend to. That’s why I brought it up. Ignorance is a weakness. You’ll now be fully abreast of your situation.”

Forcing herself to calm down, Tori leaned hard on her logic. It wasn’t entirely Ivan’s fault; she’d known she was signing on with Fornax from day one. Learning from a legend had come with plenty of perks and a few downsides—this was just one more notch in the latter column. Part of her was chapped that she was only just now getting this variable, but it didn’t change things in the larger picture.

The underworld needed a keeper. A limit. A code. And it would have one, a code built by those who knew how to walk the line of criminal and civilian, enforced by some of the most deadly monsters to claim the Earth’s surface as their home. Bad a mastermind as he was, Deacon *had* created the perfect stage to send a message. He thought it would be some pissing contest with the capes; instead, his gang would be the warning to the underworld. The monsters were still here, and their claws had a very long reach.

“Appreciate the heads up, though I wouldn’t have minded it sooner. Go ahead with the plan. I’ll take my chances with the Champions’ Congress. Won’t be my first time bullshitting my way out of trouble.” Ivan nodded,



but before he could turn, Tori kept going. “Any advice for that scenario, if it comes up?”

Ivan took his time responding. This was likely the last moment they wouldn’t feel the pounding of the clock until the rescue was done. “Quorum will see through any lie or deceit—only use the factual truth around him. If you cannot answer a question in that way, then refuse. You’re a victim, not a suspect, at least so far as the public knows. Professor Quantum is unlikely to notice or care that you’re in the building beyond a cursory handshake. Don’t try to draw his attention, and you won’t have it. Lodestar...”

His voice trailed off for a moment, like Ivan’s tongue had gotten lost in the journey. “Lodestar will have your best interests at heart. That doesn’t mean you should tell her everything, mind you, only that she very rarely uses subterfuge. It makes her both entirely predictable, and incredibly dangerous. No matter how sincere or kind she is, remember that you’re still a criminal talking to one who bows to the law. Get too honest, and there’s only so many ways it can end.”

“Thanks.” Had it been anyone else, Tori would have let the conversation end there. But Ivan was her mentor, her teacher, and as her fake uncle, he was the closest thing to family she had left. “This will go well, right? I don’t need to worry?”

Sometimes, Ivan let himself forget that Tori’s bluster was often just that, the outward lashings of someone who’d had to grow up young and fast. She was less than a decade older than Rick, and already out here facing these kinds of situations with a locked jaw. Of course she was scared deep down; she’d been taken off the damn street and trapped in a strange room. Ivan’s blood tried to boil, but he held it in check. Anger was not the tool for this occasion.

“Tori, I don’t have much in this life I care about. My children, the guild I helped found, and the few friends I’ve made along the way. I count you in that last group. You have only seen me fight when I thought someone had taken two of those from me. That is nothing compared to the hell I bring when fighting to keep one of those few people safe.”

Ivan didn’t approach her again, but he did hunch slightly, making sure they were at eye level across the room, the sea of stars to his back. “You don’t need to worry one bit. I know this isn’t what you’re used to, but the guild is more than a code and a warning of what happens to any who cross it. We are a unified organization, filled with people who want you back for

both personal and pride-based reasons. This isn't just your fight anymore. You're part of something bigger. We've got your back."

"Well then, don't keep a lady waiting. These cuffs are starting to chafe."

Just before he disappeared back through the hole, Ivan paused long enough to deliver a quick parting, one last reassurance to tide Tori over.

"See you soon."

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## Chapter 29

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Dawn was coming. Those who lurked in the night knew this feeling well. Night's energy began to wane, the chaos under the moon calming, growing still. Madness and shadow were preparing to fall away, yielding ground to the cleansing light of day. Soon, the sky would turn gray, evening's final grip faltering once more... but not yet. There was darkness left to burn, still time to do things that had no place in the sunshine.

While a large show of force might have been more impressive, that wasn't what tonight was about. This was a mission and a message, which might have tilted it toward a bigger entry team if not for the fact that no survivors would remain to talk about what they saw. For this to work, there couldn't be anyone left to talk, to contradict the guild's fabrication. No, what remained of these overly confident kidnappers would be the message itself, along with the rumors they sent running through the shadows.

Ivan stood in the late summer air, watching a group of what felt like nervous children whispering amongst themselves a small distance off. That was unfair. Tori's fellow new guild members were all adults, and it was hardly their fault that this was their first time rescuing a kidnapped colleague. Nevertheless, he was glad they'd been placed out here on the sidelines. They didn't need to be part of what was coming next. Not when the guild had such talented options to call upon.

Technically speaking, assembling Morgana, Xelas, and Arcanicus, on top of having Ivan dressed as Pseudonym waiting in the wings, was *massive* overkill for a job of this level. Were they simply sending a message out of responsibility, there would never have been a need to call upon so much

power in a single location. However, this was not just about keeping crooks in line. Someone had dared to touch a member of the guild. For the safety of everyone who depended on its protection—both the villains and those they loved—such a thing could not stand. Even if no one knew who Tori was now, that might change down the road. One slip-up, one show of weakness; that was all it took to embolden the dumbest, most dangerous of the lot. They would allow no such failing in the guild.

“Credit to them, whatever shit they’re using works ‘til the end. I can’t get a scan on the building,” Xelas said. “We’re going in blind, unless magic decided to come through.”

“Sadly, they appear to have brought in some sort of localized mana disruption generator.” Arcanicus, unlike Xelas, seemed slightly pleased by his discovery. “I’d assumed they were using actual magic to shield or obscure their location, but if they’re leaning on a tool like that, then odds are strong that none of them wield arcane talents. We can also be sure they don’t have anything enchanted in there. The disruption generator would erode the magic over time and turn such items unstable.”

Everyone looked a tad relieved. Even having two magic-users of their own, keeping the mystic arts out of battle made things more predictable. A potent magical-meta could really throw normal fights for a loop, their results often only outdone by the reality warpers like Captain Bullshit. Despite that, technically speaking, his power wasn’t magic. He’d once turned almost the entire world into living stuffed animals for an hour, though, so it was certainly something.

“No magic means we can sling a few spells ourselves, unless that generator will cause you issues?” Morgana wore her blood-red armor tonight, markedly different simply in that she was the only one of the three who had come to this soiree in different clothes. Xelas favored the natural steel look, and Arcanicus seemed like the kind of man born in his draping wizard robes. Sometimes Ivan wondered where Morgana got the blood to start her costumes, but he’d been around long enough to know that there were questions best left unanswered.

The question earned a scoff from Arcanicus. “I am no paltry practitioner just learning his spells. My magic can more than hold up to such technology, certainly long enough to see the task through.”

While Arcanicus was showing his age, and had been for some while, no one questioned the claim. In his prime, he’d been one of the most

formidable casting metas the world had ever seen. Even weakened by the bastard known as time, his arcane knowledge was among the most well-developed in the world. Whatever estimations he made of his power, they were going to be accurate.

“Two entrances. Let’s assume both are guarded. Morgana goes with Arcanicus, who magics them sneakily up to the front while I come tearing in through the back. We punch in, taking out enemies and hunting the package. Pseudonym stays out here with the rescue team. Any enemies get out, he picks them off. If we discover the package is in danger, we relay a location to Pseudonym, who will secure it and then hand it off to the rescue team, covering their exit while the rest of us finish the job. Any questions?”

New members sometimes wondered why an entity as seemingly half-cracked as Xelas was in a position of leadership. The older ones knew better. They’d been around long enough to see what happened when Xelas stopped laughing. Once she got serious, the bodies piled up fast.

“Do we have any more information on the one we’re supposed to spare besides the name and the fact he’s big?” Morgana asked.

Pseudonym shook his head. “That was all she had time to tell me. From the footage of the kidnapping, there appears to only be the one. If it becomes a problem...”

“I know. Nicety, not a priority. He’s still lumped in with these blood sacks.” Morgana held out her hand, a chunk of red armor on her arm re-liquefying and curling up, shaping itself into a sword before it hardened once more. “Councilors, are you ready?”

“Ready.” Arcanicus already had a spell half-woven in his hands, tendrils of blue light winding around him and Morgana both.

“Ready.” Xelas’s eyes lit up, and several panels on her body shifted alignment. When the assault came, few even had a chance to see which of her weapons was the one that struck them down.

“Ready.” Pseudonym cast his eyes to the new guild members. Bahamut was clutching a suitcase tightly to her scaly chest. They were scared for their friend, and not without good reason. But they were also scared for what was about to happen. Large-scale slaughter still affected them. Deep down, Ivan envied that.

Morgana tilted her blade toward the building. “Let’s go show these bastards what happens to any who challenge our guild.”



A pair of twos. All day playing intermittent poker to pass the time, and this was one of the better hands he'd gotten. Darius was starting to wonder if he'd busted a mirror recently, because luck did not seem to be with him.

With one eye always on Deacon, as a good bodyguard should, he raised some paperclips. Playing with cash was impractical, especially around other criminals, so cheap office supplies had long ago become the stand-in. One of the many tricks he'd found in his years doing this sort of work.

TV was favored by many to pass the hours, but Darius found it too dangerous. Anything that lulled a brain into complacency was working against them. Games, especially ones with stakes, kept minds active and sharp. Losing focus meant losing money, and this was not the sort of crowd to easily part with their pennies. Sometimes, punches were thrown, yet even that was good to keep the blood pumping, so long as the tussles were ended swiftly.

Across the table, his opponents were examining their own options. Did they look nervous? Keeping his expectations in check, Darius wondered if this might actually be a stronger hand than he'd known. If they were weak, this could be the time to push, to put that luck of his to the test for—

The explosion came from the rear entrance without warning. Too loud, *far* too loud for what would have been required to knock out that door. And if something had been approaching, unless it was coming stupid fast, their guy watching the cameras would have noticed. Had... had someone fired a missile into their door? That seemed crazy, yet it was the only explanation that made immediate sense.

Moving on instinct, Darius was already up, shielding Deacon with his considerable size. "Boss, we need to go."

"One explosion doesn't mean the fight is lost," Deacon protested. "We've got weaponry these capes aren't expecting; our battle has only just begun." As he spoke, the others were already scrambling for their borrowed gear—heaps of cobbled-together components shaped roughly into usable tools. A few were already turned on, letting out low-level hums or gaining glows along their blades.

Maybe, if it had been capes, Deacon would have been right. It didn't matter, though, as something that used to be a person came stumbling into the room before Darius's eyes. Half its flesh was roasted off; crackling

sparks ran along its exposed bone, until balance failed and it landed in a heap of smoking bones and meat. The final vestiges of life faded as its skinless hand reached for them, finally falling limp.

“Capes don’t kill people like that. We have to go *now*.”

Not waiting for permission, Darius scooped his employer up and raced deeper into the building. He was just around the corner when he heard the front door—in the room where they’d been playing cards moments before—slam heavily open. After that, it was hard to make out anything over the screaming. Instant, horrific, and impossibly sustained. Whatever was happening, someone was making it hurt.

“She was right. Fuck me, she was right the whole time.” Rumors. Whispers. Stories that big crime bosses tell up-and-coming conquerors to keep them in line. Except this wasn’t a cape raid. Darius had seen plenty of those, had even been rounded up in a few. The AHC didn’t come in melting flesh and exploding doors. This left only one plausible explanation: the stories were true, and the guild wasn’t as out of commission as he’d thought.

“That woman did this?” Deacon snapped, trying to look up from his position under Darius’s arm.

“More like she knew it would happen.” Zipping around a corner, Darius heard horrified yells coming from the left, and silence from the right. Right it was, then. He took the turn with minimal loss of momentum. Without realizing it, Darius had put himself on a path to Emory’s quarters. As the only two decent metas and bodyguards, they had the best chance of fighting their way out, minimal though that was starting to seem.

Perhaps there was another way. Tori hadn’t been especially subtle, hinting that she knew more than she was letting on. If it wasn’t all fake, wasn’t all just shit-talking, then maybe she could do something, say something. He was grasping at straws and was perfectly aware of that, but straws were all he had to grab in the moment.

Darius slapped open Emory’s door, shattering the lock and revealing a room with a spray of clothing and bedsheets coating its floor. The noise must have woken Emory up, and he’d gone looking for them. Damn it. No time to search, not without a lead. They’d head for Tori’s cell and hope to run into him on the way.

“Don’t worry, boss, I got you. We’ll make it through this.” Wishing he felt even a fraction as sure as his voice sounded, Darius sprinted off once

more, hoping against hope that his shitty luck had worn itself out on the poker table.



The clucking “tsks” sounded not quite right as Nexus strolled along the near empty hallway, stepping over a smoldering leg. Too easy, that was the problem. These goons might have had top-tier concealment tech, but the weapons they’d been sold weren’t nearly of the same caliber. Against average metas, sure, a double-chamber anti-ion blast would do some real damage. Facing down three councilors of the guild? A white flag would give one a better chance of survival. In some versions, they got the really good stuff, and while those fights ended the same, they were at least more fun to watch.

Reaching a hand out, Nexus ran his fingertips along the walls. Where they touched, a seam opened, revealing a swirling mass of colors and chaos not unlike his kaleidoscope eyes. From the shifting realms came a form, big as a wolf, long like a snake, armored like an insect, and with many-toothed mouths at both ends. One end opened, firing a stream of pink liquid that bubbled and hissed the moment it touched concrete, dissolving the material in seconds. More beings followed, some locking mouths, working together, rolling and slithering in a wholly unnatural way as they scattered throughout the building.

These would certainly not be enough to make any difference in the fight. Nexus reeled at the memories of what it actually took to put down these three. Other worlds, other days, he’d seen the carnage they could call upon when threatened. Eventually, they wore down, yet the results always had major, lasting consequences on that iteration. Universes like this one, versions with *multiple* Singulars, had to be managed more delicately. One true indulgence today might cost years of entertainment down the line. This was just something to add a little spice to the morning’s events.

Nexus continued along the hallway, ignoring the sounds of slithering invaders as he headed to his next viewing location. There were still a few turning points left to observe, and he loathed coming in late to these things. It never felt as good as catching it from the start.



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## Chapter 30

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Picking off survivors was far from Morgana's idea of a good time, or even a sporting challenge, but then, that's why this wasn't a job for the heroic metas.

From behind a wall, two men came leaping, both holding technological weaponry. It made no difference. She'd already felt the blood in their veins long before drawing close, and as they moved, she took control of it, turning their inner liquid into blades and spears that came bursting out of their flesh. Morgana took care to mangle their bodies, ensuring that an autopsy would give nothing away. There was a time to work in secret, a time to leave a trace, and knowing the difference often defined who went to jail versus who walked free.

A new noise came from behind her. Whipping around, Morgana formed a shield of blood out of the two bodies' contribution to her pool. Pink liquid struck, popping and sizzling, actually managing to burn through some of her defenses.

"What in the hells...?" A single glance answered her question. Three unnatural creatures, slapping and rolling and slithering with disgusting speed, were coming to join a fourth with a drip of pink liquid falling from its front mouth—or at least, the mouth that was in front at this particular moment. Neither seemed especially dominant, and worse, whatever was in these otherworldly creatures wasn't blood.

"Arcanicus, looks like we've got interlopers. Maybe part of their defense, but it wouldn't be my bet. Can you send word out to Pseudonym that things might get complicated?"

“Of course.” Arcanicus raised his hands, creating a circle of white fire around the four monsters. In moments, the fire rushed inward, surging over all of them. It took a full minute for them to burn, by the end of which Arcanicus had completed sending his mystical message. Given that they were walking into a place blocking all tech, magical relay had made the most sense for communicating.

His gaze turned worried as he looked on, noting the smoldering remains. “These things are harder than they look. Bonfire would cook a normal human in seconds, someone like Thuggernaut in a half-minute, tops.”

Sudden, strange creatures appearing on the scene fit several old metas’ methods, but those would all be a stretch. The most obvious answer was usually right, and with this, Nexus may as well have signed his name on one of the creatures. He very well might have, in fact; it wasn’t like he cared much for subtlety.

“Should we find Xelas?” Since their robotic colleague was entirely formed of technology, her ability to interact with magic was limited, and that included mystical messages. It was a risk they’d realized going in; however, given the limitations of the job, there was no avoiding it.

Arcanicus stroked his beard twice, then his head shook. “If I can handle them, she’ll be fine. The larger job is purging these things before any make their way to the package. I doubt they will show a kidnapper’s restraint.”

“Pushing on it is.” Morgana reached out, feeling the next sacks of waiting blood. She’d have to be more careful now; there were entities in the mix she couldn’t instantly destroy. There might have been, perhaps, a hint of a smile on Morgana’s face as she adjusted the grip on her sword.

Now *this* was a little more entertaining.



The clang of the door unlocking startled Tori. She had no way of gauging the time precisely, but it had been long enough that she knew the moment was drawing close. Though this felt early, it was also a good sign. The capes must be here to set her free. Affecting a weary, scared expression was harder than she expected, especially when she had to hurry to compose

herself as the door pushed open. She didn't end up doing a very good job, not that it mattered. The man standing before her was certainly not a cape.

"They put you in this one? Curious. Usually, you're a few doors down." Nexus stepped back, checking the hallway like a lost tourist, then shrugging in acceptance. "Oh well. The surprises are what make it interesting."

"Why do you always show up at the worst times?" Tori wasn't sure when the madman's presence had turned from shocking development to occasional annoyance. Maybe she just didn't have the spare energy to spend on him right now.

He wagged a finger at her, something she'd only seen from old professors and bad television. "Not the worst parts, the fun parts. The bits worth seeing. True, some are better than others, but even on the rewatch, I don't like to skip anything... especially since the details are never *quite* the same. Don't worry. You rarely die in all this."

The door began to close once more, going just slow enough for her to hear Nexus's parting words. "Of course, I also don't usually bring along acid-spitting friends. I wonder how that will impact things."

The door shut loudly; however, there was no sound of it locking. Nexus wasn't worried about her escaping—wasn't worried about anything at all, most likely. More force of nature than person, he was a long-standing thorn that countless wanted to pull out, yet no one had succeeded. Today wasn't the time to worry about Nexus. More concerning was whatever it was he'd let loose, and how it was going to impact the rescue mission.

Taking a deep breath, Tori forced herself to stay calm and ignore her now unlocked door. This wasn't about escape; a door could never have held her if she'd opted to leave. It was about building a story, a message, and an alibi all in one go. The others had her back. She just needed to trust that they'd be able to handle whatever bumps Nexus put in the way.

It wasn't a terribly hard leap of faith, knowing her guild and its power. If anything, she started to wonder what was taking so long.



"Come on... come on... finally!" Xelas pulled her finger from the massive computer tower, a USB port vanishing as her digit reformed. Though there were receivers and components spread throughout the building, she'd

needed to find the digital heart for her side mission. There was no shame in someone else creating tech that rivaled the guild's; such was the nature of progress and innovation. However, there was no way they were dealing with this a second time. Xelas had just downloaded all the software and schematics, her ocular sensors scanning every component that wasn't shielded. They'd have to do a little guesswork here and there, but that was no major hurdle for her and Doctor Mechaniacal.

One piece caught her attention in particular. Directly at the center of the machine, buried deep in its core, was a box that read like a black hole. It was so shielded and dense that it had to be intentional, some sort of lure meant to draw in the too-curious. Another time, she might have probed further. Today was not the time to risk a trap, however. One of their own had been taken, and they needed to make clear why that was a horrendous idea.

Xelas turned the corner just in time to see a pair of tube-like monsters joined at the mouth slide past the door she'd exited. The pair slapped around, what looked like nine tongues coming out of each mouth to taste the air, walls, and concrete. No reaction. Probably didn't distinguish her as a life form. It wasn't uncommon with interlopers; they reacted to the biological because it was what they were familiar with.

Choosing a midrange weapon, Xelas shot the one on the right, the bolt from her shoulder searing and wounding it, but not finishing the job. Tough little bastards; that would have gone clean through a car. Pink liquid shot out from the left one's mouth, a stream that Xelas easily dodged. This time, she picked something with more stopping power. A flash of yellow as the beam struck, and now the one on the left was sliced cleanly in two.

More pink gushed from its insides, ruining the flooring. Another blast to finish off the right one, which was unhooking its connected mouth from its now dead cohort. It never had time to finish before her beam hit.

"These'll liven things up." Xelas was already moving, acutely aware that the introduction of an unknown factor could spin their plans out of control. She moved so fast, in fact, that Xelas missed what came only half a minute after the monsters were killed.

That's how long it took for the new flesh to start growing.



Careening down a hall, Darius ducked into an alcove to catch his breath. He set Deacon down, eyes peeled for whoever was cutting down their gang at a rapid clip. They were still a ways off from Tori's cell—some of the screaming had forced them on a circuitous route. Not knowing what they were up against, Darius couldn't risk engaging, especially with the boss in tow.

"You need a break already?" Despite his people being roasted and butchered, Deacon was somehow more angry than sad or scared.

"If I'm gassed and need to defend you, we're as good as done." A noise caught Darius's ears: movement, action... was someone fighting? They were directly across from the room with some free weights and chairs, jokingly called "the gym" by everyone here. Was it possible one of the others had survived? "Hang on, we might have backup."

Darius had only gotten a few steps when Deacon's hand grabbed his arm. "Absolutely not. Whatever is happening in there is none of our concern. Do your job, bodyguard. Get me to the girl so we can put an end to this."

While both a professional and a veteran at working for dickheads, Darius did have his limits. Suddenly finding himself fighting for survival stole a lot of the energy he usually dedicated toward patience. Perhaps that was why he snapped up Deacon by the neck and pinned him to the wall.

"Put an end to this? Look around, you egotistical nut. This is over. It's been over from the moment you convinced us to steal a civilian off the street. Do you think we're coming back from this? Those screams aren't just noises. Those are your people! My friends! And it's your fault we're in this mess."

Only... was it? Deacon was ignorant of the rules or blinded by ambition. Darius had neither excuse. He'd known the risks, heard the warnings, and still hadn't managed to turn Deacon from these tactics. If anyone was responsible for all this, it might very well be Darius himself.

Releasing his grip, the big meta allowed Deacon to drop back to the ground, where he immediately scrambled to his feet and dashed off. Most likely to his death, though there was always the chance he'd wriggle free. Rats had a talent for survival.

With Deacon out of the way, Darius's attention was drawn back to the noises from the gym. He ripped the door clean off, unveiling a very curious-looking fight. Emory was darting around, avoiding a trio of two-headed

nightmare snakes spitting sizzling pink goo. Occasionally, he'd whip a free weight at one, but the damned things could dodge with hideous grace.

Not one to waste time, Darius hefted up the first weight he could find and slammed it down onto the nearest snake head.

It definitely left an impact—cracks along the head were dripping pink goop—however, the blow wasn't enough to crush the head completely. Given Darius's size and strength, that said a lot about how durable these things were, as well as how fucked the gang might be. If his strength wasn't enough, and Emory's venom would presumably be limited on their anatomy, then this was a bad fight. There was no way to win; they'd just wear down until someone made a mistake.

"Emory, we need to go." At his words, the monsters seemed to grow more active. Did they understand, or just realize more prey was in the room?

"Tried that. They spray down the exit if I get near. I think they've locked in on me as prey."

The dissolved sections of room made it obvious what that pink stuff did, even if Darius couldn't see it happening for himself as one sprayed toward Emory. Four of them, two mouths apiece, with only one being a little smashed up. Too many streams. The creatures could cover every angle. This was a fight they couldn't win, or escape, especially presuming that there were more enemies still to account for—unless these creatures could also create explosions and roast skin.

"I've got an idea!" Darius leapt into the room proper, dodging a spray of pink as he arrived at Emory's side. "Give me your hand, quick!"

Just like a good student, Emory did as instructed. Darius didn't hesitate. He jerked Emory into a bear-hug, wrapping his sizable heft around the smaller crook. After that, Darius was running. He heard the sounds of the jaws opening while he was still ten feet from the door. The first stream hit as he was crossing through, with a second and third right on its heels. Pain came quickly, his clothes turning to nothing, exposing his flesh. Like most burly metas, Darius was tough on top of being big, something he was counting on to buy them both extra steps.

Unfortunately, one of streams hit his left leg, slowing the run down considerably. Darius could hear the monsters following, slapping and slithering as they gave chase, fresh sprays of pink searing his back. The acid

was stronger than he'd expected, a realization that came as his legs began to buckle.

No. They weren't far enough yet. They needed to get away, to give Emory a head start, a fighting chance. Darius was still trying to push himself forward when his legs suddenly went numb. The goo must have gotten a piece of his spine. Part of Darius wanted to see how much of his back even remained, but he knew it was a sight that would haunt the short remainder of his life.

Legs gone, arms wrapped around a struggling Emory, and monsters drawing close. This was looking bleak. Then came a flash of yellow to his left and squeals of pain from behind.

Glancing back, Darius saw all the monsters sliced up, carved neatly down their centers. Looking forward again, he discovered himself looking up at the form of Xelas. Famous for many reasons, not the least of which was her affiliation to the guild at the center of the Ridge City Riots.

It was all true. The legends, the warnings, the secret cabal patrolling the underground. All of it real, and Darius had ignored the warnings. He was already dead, his body in the process of dissolving from interloper acid. He wasn't gone just yet, though. There might still be time to save one.

"Please... he's just a kid. My fault all this happened. I knew. I knew, and I ignored, but he didn't. He was only starting... didn't know... my fault. My fault."

Darius continued to whisper the words as his voice grew hoarse. They slipped from his mouth while Xelas leaned down, chose a precise spot on the skull, and struck. No more words, or pain, as he dropped limply to the ground. Big guy, showing concern for others; this was definitely the one Tori said to spare if they could.

Flipping him over, Xelas revealed another meta, one with serpent-like physical markings. He was scared and panicked, not shocking since a friend of his had just died on top of him. Snap judgment time. They didn't owe this guy shit, especially considering the circumstances. But Darius had been the one Tori asked be spared, and he'd given his life to save the kid. Logic said the smartest path was to kill him here and get on with the job. Xelas was more than a mere robot, however. She could see past the simple logic, taking into account that Darius had been decent enough that Tori wanted to save him, and that he'd died helping a friend.

Humans talked a lot of crap about love, loyalty, and honor. Most of it was just that, too: pure shit, fantasies to make themselves feel like better people than they were. Every now and then, however, one would actually live up to those lofty ideals, if only for a moment. Seeing those instances was one of Xelas's favorite parts of being around their kind, watching their own self-serving fiction catalyze into reality. Maybe this guy was worth saving, most likely he wasn't. That would be up to him to decide, though.

One shot from the mini-injector canon was all it took to knock the new prisoner out. Xelas slung him over her shoulder, preparing to resume the search for Tori. However, getting positioned took long enough that by the time she was ready to move on, Xelas noticed movement coming from the bisected monster corpses. Specifically, she noticed the new limbs and body parts growing at an incredible rate.

"Oh, fuck me. I just had to pick today to get a pet." Emory still unconscious on her shoulder, Xelas ran off down the nearest hall, wondering if she'd find a way to warn the others.



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## Chapter 31

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“Sir.”

The aide stood at the door, waiting for permission to enter the office. When Professor Quantum was working, he loathed to be interrupted; however, this was a Priority One message. No wiggle room on these. It had to be brought to a member of the Champions’ Congress. Quorum and Lodestar were out in the field, meaning that only Professor Quantum was immediately on hand.

It took a full two minutes before Professor Quantum looked up from the desk where he was tinkering with some curious device. Silently, he waved the aide in. He didn’t even make eye contact, instead staring at the place where the messenger would stand.

She took the order, striding over and opening the page in her hands. “Sir, there was a wild dimensional breach detected. Seems to have come from Michigan, near the Detroit area. Something interfered with the reading, so we’re having trouble pinpointing the location.”

“Interesting.” That wasn’t just a canned reply. For the first time, Professor Quantum appeared to be paying attention to the conversation. “Our dimension doesn’t experience wild breaches anymore. The most common instances now are metas accidentally creating rips, and Nexus, with the latter considerably outweighing the former.”

The aide’s face paled. “Oh no. Not today. We still haven’t recovered that woman, and now Nexus is on the move?”

“Unlikely. His big displays are more overt. Nexus is like a carrion fly, drawn to the scent of blood.” Professor Quantum considered for a moment

longer. “Push some of our resources into searching Detroit, and start moving assets there. I have a hunch that might just be where we find our missing civilian.”

“Yes, sir.” The aide paused, looking at the Priority Three alert also on the page. Technically, this one didn’t require immediate attention, but if she told him now, she could skip going through this again later. “One more thing, probably not related. Some of our monitoring tech caught a message being fired into space less than an hour ago. We couldn’t see what it said, only that one went out.”

“Not many terrestrial devices capable of that. I’ll consider it.” Professor Quantum went back to his project, a not-so-subtle way of ending the conversation.

That was fine by the aide. She was more than ready to leave. It wasn’t even dawn, and this was already shaping into a hell of day.



“Holy crap!”

Morgana spun around to find Arcanicus staring at two hideous monsters. A mound of grasping claws, with a body covered in mouths endlessly opening and closing, one head rising off the back like a scorpion’s tail. A familiar head, at that. It looked like one of the snake creatures, only hacked in half and stuck on top of something even more disgusting.

“Sweet sorcery, that made my heart skip a beat.” Arcanicus gestured and a wall of Bonfire appeared between him and the creatures. It was just in time as the body’s dozen mouths opened, firing streams of pink liquid in every direction. The bits that hit his magic walls sizzled and hissed. Potent acid though it might be, the defenses of a guild councilor were not so easily broken. “Do you think they’re evolving?”

“Adapting would be my guess. Maybe they’re like worms, regrowing a body that’s been cut in half. Only they do it in their own terrible way.” Morgana looked through the flames. The first versions had been the size of normal dogs. These ones were closer to mastiffs. “Burn them to ash. We can’t take chances. Then give Pseudonym the update. These things probably won’t stay in the building for long.”

“Should we adjust the plan? Might not be safe to leave the package for extraction.”

That was a damn good question, one Morgana wished she had a quick answer for. Nexus had, as Nexus often did, fucked things up considerably. They still had dead gang members to put in place, but the tale they’d been spinning was muddled. First, they needed to make sure Tori was safe. After they’d completed the rescue, they could decide how to manage the spin.



Though Morgana didn’t know it, the interlopers had already begun to spill from the building. Much as Ivan wanted to leave them be, knowing that dead creatures outside the building would raise questions, he couldn’t risk one of them escaping into the night. These entities couldn’t last long here—even getting through to this plane of existence was only thanks to Nexus—but they were capable of serious destruction with the time they had.

“Glyph, seal off the back door. Pest Control, get us some eyes. Bahamut, set down the suitcase. You’re with me.”

In a blink, both literal and magical, Ivan appeared in front of the first creature. A spray of pink shot out, just as Arcanicus had warned. He didn’t even bother to dodge, letting it fizzle ineffectively off his wards. Picking up the nearest monster, Ivan grabbed both heads and squeezed. It took more force than he’d been expecting, but both soon popped like he’d gripped a juice box too hard. More pink dripped down his hands, not that it mattered. The wards were just to protect his costume; this sort of attack wasn’t even capable of hurting him.

“Bahamut, do you have any sort of immunity to acid?”

“Not that I know of.” She was almost to his side already, quite fast in her green dragon form. “Just kind of tough, in general.”

Expected, but not ideal. “Then you’re on crowd control. Dodge the acid, but keep them corralled. Throw them back toward me, if needed. Once Glyph seals off the rear exit, this will be the funnel they all come through. Be ready for a rush at any time.”

“Shouldn’t we be going after Tori? You know, now that there are crazy acid monsters, it seemed like maybe the plan might be scrapped.”

“Perhaps, perhaps not. We needed a scapegoat for the capes to look at. Nexus works as well as the gang did. Better, in some ways, since he was actually part of this.” Ivan grabbed another creature and popped both heads. He was going faster, now that he knew the amount of strength required. “Regardless, that’s up to the ones inside. We help by clearing them a safe exit, and ensuring the message isn’t muddled by one of these things escaping and melting a hospital.”

That seemed to placate her, for a moment. “What if she’s in trouble? What if she calls for help?”

“Then I’ll rip the building in half and be at her side in an instant.” No laughter or ego in that statement. It was purely factual, and Bahamut could see that. Just because they were using the delicate method now didn’t mean they could switch to force if needed. They were both excellent tactics in a villain’s toolkit.

Darting past one of the creatures, Bahamut gripped it by the middle and hurled it toward Ivan, who snagged it from the air and crushed it between his hands, seemingly without effort. “If that happens, bring me along.”

“Sorry, but no. Not how we work. You want to be there with me in a moment like that?” Ivan dropped the mangled corpse to the ground, where its pink blood immediately began to dissolve the grass, despite leaving Ivan’s hands unblemished. “Become strong enough to get there yourself.”



This time, there was no preamble or warning. The door swung open, not quite powerfully enough to bang against the wall. To be fair, it was a heavy one, and Deacon was not a man burdened by excess muscle.

He looked like hell, which was honestly still better than Tori had expected by this point. She’d assumed he’d be crushed, melted, skewered—really it was just a question of who the guild had sent that would determine what form his death would take. Yet somehow, here he was, panicked and trying his damndest to get the door shut once more.

“Things not going great? Feels early for another bathroom break. You don’t want to spoil me.”

“Shut the fuck up!” Deacon whipped around at her, snapping the words. He was way off-kilter, not that he’d seemed overly stable to begin with.

This was a step beyond, though. Between Nexus popping up and the guild being there, she didn't know exactly what was going down, but she could make some fair assumptions.

Behind her back, Tori phased her left wrist into fire form for a split second, letting the metal cuff slip through, catching it in her right hand before it could fall and rattle the chain. This felt like a situation where having both hands and not being stuck to a chair might be advantageous, but she didn't want to play her cards just yet. If she was doing this, then she was going all the way. And there was one major question she wanted answered before Deacon was off the board.

"Seems like it's just you and me. No underlings or goons to impress. Be honest: how did you get blocking equipment good enough to stall the AHC?"

"Why the hell would I tell you that? Why I would help *you* at all?" Deacon was scouring his pockets, refusing to face the harsh realization that he didn't have a key to lock the door with.

"Because it's pretty obvious that whoever gave you that tech knew you'd fail. They were using you. No idea for what, but this plan was doomed from the jump, and anyone smart enough to build that kind of shit could probably see it."

Fury boiled up in Deacon's eyes as he stalked across the room, glowering down at Tori. "I have had enough of your mouth, enough of your hollow courage, enough of *you*. You may very well be right; I probably will die here with the rest of my crew. But at least I can take those flapping gums of yours with me."

And just like that, he reached in to choke her.

It might have scared Tori, if he'd been faster or more aggressive, but ultimately, Deacon didn't have any practice at this. Anger was carrying him past where his normal boldness would have faltered. Tori let him come, adjusting her grip on the cuff slightly, pushing the ratchet all the way through until the cuff was open again. She let him get his hands around her neck, waited until he'd begun to squeeze in earnest. His eyes locked, he was set on the task at hand.

That was when Tori struck, driving the sharp ratchet arm of her open cuff directly into Deacon's left leg. She yanked it out just as his screams began to bubble forth and his grip loosened, which made her kick to his stomach land all the harder.

He stumbled back, coughing and clutching his wounded leg, while Tori stood from her chair.

“You... bitch...”

“Hey, count yourself lucky. I was aiming for your crotch, my angle was just shit.” At long last, Tori’s own rage could show itself. These people had taken her off the street, threatened her life, the lives of her friends, and even tried to kill her at the end. Worst of all, because of them, she’d had to see something she’d have been happier not knowing. This incident had shown Tori the truth of their world. Capes weren’t enough. It needed horrors, demons, unfathomable monsters who still had things to protect. People outside of morality, yet not ones who’d completely lost their humanity.

The world needed villains.

Tori let the other half of the cuffs phase off her wrist, setting them down on the chair. “It’s funny that you’re blaming me for all of this. How many different ways did I say to let me go or everyone would die?”

There weren’t even words this time, just a guttural scream as Deacon charged, swinging wildly. He was better than she’d expected, but that didn’t mean he was good. Not compared to someone with guild training and Tori’s own experience.

She sidestepped the charge, tripping him and pushing his skull so he went careening into the chair. Both landed with a clatter, though the chair wasn’t bleeding from its head.

“Not so easy when you have to throw the punches, is it?” Tori stalked closer to him. “I always hated your kind. The ‘mastermind’ who sits on a throne of inactivity while everyone else gets their hands dirty. I’ve seen so many gangs like this, so many kings of tiny kingdoms who mistake their groups’ power for their own.”

“The fuck are you talking about?” Deacon had stopped rubbing his stomach and was trying to stand once more. “You work in a downtown office.”

Tori made no move to stop him from rising. She wanted him back on his feet. “People have secrets. Some you can’t find through even the most dedicated web-browsing. You’re supposed to be a smart one. Have you pieced together mine yet?”

Slowly, Deacon found his balance, standing despite his wounds and exhaustion. Had Tori liked him, she might have found the gesture inspiring.

Instead, it just made for a more convenient position. This time, she planned to get her angles right.

“Meta-human, obviously.” He spit blood from his mouth a few times. Evidently, he’d gathered quite a bit during that chair collision. “Of all the fucking luck, we ended up taking a meta.”

“Oh no, that would have been much better for you.” Tori walked closer. “See, there was only one true lie I told during the so-called interrogation. It was never *them* coming from the shadows to get you. It was *us*.”

She grabbed him by the back of the head, leading Deacon to struggle. One punch just below the sternum put a quick end to that, however. He was gasping now, trying so hard to draw in breath. Perfect. Lifting her right arm, Tori turned the entire appendage into living flame.

“You didn’t just kidnap a civilian, or a meta, or a cape’s friend. You stepped into the ring with real villains. This was the only way it could have ended.”

Her arm rammed past his lips and teeth, down the throat, reached all the way down into his lungs. The air inside them roasted instantly, the organs themselves soon catching fire, along with the rest of Deacon. Tori held it like that until he was truly alight—this was no time for half-measures—then pulled her arm out, returning it to normal form.

The burning body of Deacon collapsed. Mostly likely, he was already dead. If not, he’d cross over soon. Just in case, Tori decided to leave him with some parting words.

“Sorry, pal, but you know the expression: if you can’t stand the heat, don’t *fuck* with Hephaestus.”

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## Chapter 32

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No sleep, barely any food, and eyes blurring between blinks. Donald had stopped short of donning a diaper, but he'd also waited so long between bathroom breaks that there were a few close calls and one photo finish. It didn't feel especially dignified or heroic to be locked in his room with Ren playing *Constable Fluffers* nonstop for hours on end, yet it was without question the best way Donald could spend his time.

Deep down, he was kicking himself. All these months, his efforts had been targeted toward field work, leveling up items and training skills he needed to be out there fighting the good fight. Only today, faced with his own utter helplessness, did Donald realize how much more there was to doing his job. Finding people in need, getting to them, securing and transporting criminals, helping the injured—it was never-ending the more he thought about it. He'd fallen into a pattern without realizing it, gotten too comfortable in the routine. It was time to widen his training scope, add some new abilities to the arsenal. After Tori was safe, of course.

It was just at the cusp of dawn when Donald stumbled into the room where he and Ren had met with the Champions' Congress less than twenty-four hours prior. Professor Quantum was the only one of the main three there, though there was a flurry of other members zipping around him. Donald was too exhausted to even recognize masks, let alone recall names. He only had eyes for the man at the top.

"Sir, Mr. Professor Quantum..."

No response, or even a glance in his direction. What the hell was going on? Turning, Donald saw Ren talking to another cape. Normal Donald



might have found the patience to wait until he was called upon. This version of Donald, the one running on no sleep and wracked with fear for his friend, wasn't quite so willing to wait.

"She's in Detroit!" He yelled the words, not especially concerned with the stares coming his way. Only one set of eyes in this room mattered, and mercifully, they did indeed swivel in his direction.

Stepping away from his conversation, Professor Quantum was there in only a few of his long-legged strides. "I see. And how did you come to this conclusion?"

"Just like I said I would. Played my game all day, got the magnifying glass, and used it." Donald didn't even have the strength to be intimidated. He just rattled off the truth as coherently as he could. "I checked it twice, same results. She's somewhere in Detroit."

Professor Quantum looked hard at Donald, giving him true attention in a way that made the younger meta uncomfortable. "This is your one chance. If you've spoken to someone, gotten an inside track, I assure you, I'll uncover it. Now, for the last time: you're saying you found her, even when the entirety of the AHC's methods had failed?"

"No. I'm saying she's in Detroit. That's a long way off from finding her."

"Hmm." One wave of Professor Quantum's hand and an aide was at his side. "This is the second time your power has accomplished something past what I'd expected. I dislike giving credit when not well-earned, but I detest being wrong. It seems I must adjust my measurement of your capabilities, Cyber Geek. We shall deal with that at another time. For now, you're heading to the med bay for recovery."

Donald almost reached out to touch Professor Quantum, then thought better of it. "Please, no. I want to be there. I want to help save her. I want to make sure she's all right."

The stare that met his pleas was unyielding. No pity, no sense of understanding, an absolute denial. The voice, however, made at least an effort toward comfort. "Your wish to be there is misguided. Given your condition, putting you in the field is more likely to cause problems than help solve them. You want her safe and saved? I cannot promise what her condition is. However, I can say this much: Lodestar and Quorum are both standing by for the moment we have a location."

There was nowhere left to take the argument. Donald certainly couldn't claim that, even at his peak, he'd be a contributing factor when two members of the Champions' Congress would be there. At Donald's current skill level, Professor Quantum was honestly right. It was more likely he'd be a liability than any sort of help. It was just... he'd finally become the kind of person who could jump in to make a difference, but when it was personal, he was on the sidelines.

"Donald, you gave them a location. You made a difference."

The fact that he hadn't even noticed Ren approach proved Professor Quantum's point, even as the older man was shaking his head. "Actually, we've known about Detroit for approximately twenty minutes. But I expect we'll be calling on that ability of yours in the future. While I had my doubts, it shows promise to be useful."

Someone called out what sounded like random numbers, drawing Professor Quantum's instant attention. He didn't even look at them, simply turned and walked away. As the aide gently took Donald's arm, leading him off toward the med bay, the bespectacled man leaned in, whispering in Donald's ear.

"For reference, 'useful' is one of the nicest things he says about anyone. Believe it or not, I think you impressed him."

Nice as that was to hear, Donald didn't feel especially impressive. He wanted to be there, part of the rescue, to see her safe. One all-nighter, and he was down for the count. Too weak, again. This couldn't keep happening. Cyber Geek was going to have to get stronger.



The plan was good and well-fucked, that much was obvious. Between Nexus being here and the smoldering corpse in her room, the original cover story was going to need some tweaks. Tori turned toward the door, making it only a few steps before it felt as if the ground fell away. Her head swam, a sensation almost like pain hitting her right in the forehead. Initially, she tried to push it away, before remembering the last time something like this had happened. Not a hard recollection to call upon, seeing as it had only been a few hours.

Mentally relaxing, Tori felt the not-quite-pain flare, then vanish. Moments later, she heard a familiar voice. Not in her ears, however. This was purely in her mind.

*Listen carefully. This is Pseudonym. Arcanicus is acting as a magical relay from inside the dampening field, but we still need to make this quick. Nexus showed up unexpectedly, complicating matters. After a quick discussion, we only see two paths forward. You can leave with us now; we have your suit. Or you could destroy the dampening equipment, summoning the AHC. With Nexus in play, you can claim to have escaped in the chaos.*

What a choice. Leave now, and risk all the questions that point might raise with the capes—to say nothing if the media ever found out that Tori had magically gone missing from her own kidnapping. Or fight her way past whatever it was Nexus let loose and hope to make it through an AHC interrogation. Tori examined the situation, taking in as many factors as she could account for.

Ultimately, it was her status as a kidnapped civilian that made the call. Right now, she was a victim, someone who'd been targeted because of her association to the capes. That would make it difficult for them to push her too hard. She'd have the public's sympathy, and the AHC was already working to win back the people. If she changed the dynamic, it almost certainly wouldn't be as favorable: Plucky victim who saved herself beat vanishing mysteriously from the site of a slaughter.

Closing her eyes and thinking the words hard, Tori hoped she was successfully talking back. Magic was messy and imprecise in her experience, which was all the more reason she preferred science.

*I'll break their system. Can you give me any sort of guidance? Info on what Nexus brought is also appreciated.*

In response, she got images, flashes of two-headed, pink-spitting serpents, and the more horrifying version that looked like a mound of mouths—one that was tough, spewed acid, and had recovered from being torn in half. This would be a game of dodge more than anything. She wasn't sure if dimensional acid worked on fire and would prefer to run such tests in a structured laboratory environment. Stay quick, move fast, and hope she found her goal soon.

*Only Xelas found the room, and she doesn't know where you are to give directions. North side of the building, the door is torn down. If you're sure*

*this is the right course, we have to start pulling back. Once the capes know where you are, she'll be here in seconds.*

It didn't escape Tori's attention that he said "she" instead of "they," but by now, his former apprentice had accepted that to Ivan, there was only one real threat the capes had to wield. For him, solely Lodestar was of concern; however, Tori still had to worry about the rest of the bunch, all of whom would be descending upon her with confusion and questions. It said a lot about Tori Rivas that she was more anxious about the impending discussion than dodging deadly monsters to secure her freedom.

*I'm sure. Get everyone out of here. I got this.*

*They'll be gone within minutes. I'll be here to the end. Just in case.*

The connection snapped off without warning, leaving Tori alone once more. No, she'd always been here by herself—that was an important distinction to keep in mind for later. Stick to the truth wherever she could. Her eyes drifted down to the smoldering corpse behind her. Well, he had been trying to strangle her, so at worse, that counted as self-defense. Probably best to avoid bringing it up, if possible.

Since the door was unlocked, there was no need to break out. She eased it open gently, ears perked for sounds of movement. There were loud thuds and noises coming from all over, yet none sounded particularly closer than the others. That meant there weren't any creatures near, or they were all right on top of her. Didn't change what she had to do next either way.

For someone without an internal compass, who'd been knocked out during her entry trip, knowing that her goal was in the north part of the building meant fuck all. The broken door part was more helpful, but as Tori checked the first such instance, it became clear that there was more than one busted barrier in this place. This one looked like a room where someone had been either hiding or resting. Neither had saved them from the eroding pink goo that appeared to have melted through half the room, occupant included.

She pushed the image away. In truth, Tori had been holding a lot of things back during this whole ordeal, and was starting to notice the strain. Good as it had felt in the moment, killing Deacon was running back through her head. This wasn't like with Rust Tooth, or some of her dodgier fights in her thief days. Those were about survival, her versus them. But she was much stronger than Deacon; he'd never been an actual threat.

More mental shoving. This was *not* the time for an ethical self-examination.

Focusing on the task at hand, Tori burst around a corner and skidded to a stop. Standing before her was one of the many-mouthed monsters, the larger version that nearly blocked the whole hallway. Its tail/head/whatever-the-hell whipped in her direction, letting off an instant blast of pink spray. Tori backpedaled, shooting off a blast of fire into the thing's center of mass. No visible reaction whatsoever. Guess it took more oomph to hurt these horrors. What she wouldn't give for her suit and its weaponry.

A fleck of acid hit her left arm, the pain sharp and immediate. Tori shifted to fire instantly, watching in horrified fascination as the droplet kept on eating through the flames. After a second or two, the heat caused it to boil off, finally freeing her from the droplet. Unfortunately, that was more than enough data to show she was vulnerable to these creatures, even in fire form. Enough of that pink goo could theoretically dissolve her before she could boil it off.

Speed had just become more important than stealth. Nowhere to hide in this concrete warehouse, so getting to the security room quickly was her biggest concern. Leaping into the air, Tori focused her flames, using the flying trick she'd learned during her first real test with the guild to get next to the ceiling. At least up here, they'd have to aim to hit her, and she could zip around without worrying about obstacles.

Her next burst of speed got her clear just in time, as a wave of pink burned the concrete right where she'd been. Sounds of movement kept her attention, and she realized the creature was giving chase. Its mouths weren't spitting acid, curiously. Instead, they seemed to be spitting out an array of unnatural, guttural slurping noises, like listening to pigs eat a trough full of yogurt. Only the tail/head kept firing, likely because it was the sole one with a chance of hitting her elevated position.

It wasn't until the next hallway that Tori understood. Three of the two-headed version and one more mouth mound were all waiting, letting loose a coordinated series of streams the moment she came into view. Only training and reflexes saved her. She shot down below the arc of the streams, putting on a burst of power and charging directly through the monsters. Their acid might hurt, but physically, they were still flesh and she was fire, meaning they couldn't actually block her path.

However, they could, it turned out, give chase. Suddenly, she was seeing pink coming from all angles, and the tight confines of the building made it impossible to break away completely. She couldn't build up speed with all the turning and checking, so Tori was forced to dodge with all she had. For the most part, she was holding together well, though she'd taken more than a few hits to the flames serving as her legs.

A big splotch got her in the back, nearly sending Tori spinning all the way to the ground, where she had no doubt a tidal wave of death was awaiting her. Ivan's lessons about pain and focus weren't for nothing, though. Leaving scorch marks on the wall, she slowed her descent, putting all her energy into heating up one section of her form. More shots came, thankfully missing, albeit barely. If she'd had teeth, they'd have been gritted as Tori gave one last push of effort and successfully turned the acid to steam.

Blasting forward, Tori took the next three turns she could, trying to buy a few inches of breathing room. Sadly, she could still hear them on her tail, but a new sight stole the entirety of her interest. A room with a broken door, and the telltale blinking twinkle of technology. She roared in, looking over the setup.

There was a massive amount of gear crammed into a single space, all of it incredibly dense. With a glance, she could recognize some of the components, yet far more were totally unfamiliar, or bore only the slightest resemblance to tech she was familiar with. Her hands, not even flesh at the moment, itched to tear it apart, see how it worked, what she could add to her own designs. The thunder of slithering following her down the hall made it clear that wasn't happening, much to her chagrin.

Raising a hand to roast the tech, she had a brief second thought. No reason to leave evidence if she didn't have to. Instead, she moved deeper into the room, her fluid form unbothered by the lack of space. In seconds, the pursuers had arrived, trying to force their way through the door all at once.

"Hey, you nasty shits. I'm right here. Maybe you can manage to hit a standing target."

The taunting probably didn't affect them—it just felt natural as Tori waved, drawing their attention. Sure enough, sprays of pink rained down. Instantly, Tori dropped back, falling behind one of the massive electronic towers. Sizzling met her ears as the goo began to tear through intricate

systems and equipment. Working carefully, she began to solidify part of herself, shoving the equipment around until she'd made a small area in the back where a human could fit.

Sitting down to present as tiny a target as possible, Tori turned back to human form. Her arm was fine, but her back and legs still stung. More time was needed to regenerate fully, it seemed. While she'd still prefer that to being human and vulnerable, there was no choice. If the AHC was going to be swooping in as fast as Ivan expected, she couldn't very well be showing powers when they arrived.

More hissing, more noises, and Tori noticed the creatures were making progress. They'd cleared out a section near the front and were slowly pushing their way toward the back where Tori was holed up. The tower in front of her took several fresh sprays, and she began to wonder if it would even last long enough for help to arrive.

Her heart pounded. This was crazy. She couldn't sit and wait. She had to move, had to get free. They were getting closer. It was just a matter of time until they—

Tori shrieked as the tower blocking her from the rest of the room vanished, almost summoning fire on instinct. But this was no dimensional monster coming to melt her flesh. They didn't even have hands, so they couldn't effortlessly lift a huge piece of electronic equipment like it was nothing, and they certainly didn't glow.

Looking up, Tori found herself gazing into one of the AHC's greatest heroes and legends, the one superhero her teacher seemed to respect, as well as fear.

“L-Lodestar?”

“That's right, Tori. Don't worry, you're safe now.” She reached out a hand, and Tori took it without thinking.

In what felt like a blink, they were in the air, Tori effortlessly cradled in Lodestar's arms. From this high up, she could see the rainbow of capes arriving on the scene. Part of her wondered if Ivan had escaped in time, but she realized that there would be far more excitement if anyone spotted Fornax here. Adrenaline fading, the toll of a sleepless night and regenerating several wounds finally hit Tori full force.

She passed out before Lodestar had even gotten them out of Michigan.

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## Chapter 33

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Every channel was talking about the rescue, some praising the AHC for recovering Tori safely, others wondering why it took so long. The destruction at the scene raised minimal eyebrows, as identical anchors with the same plastic smiles repeated the most salient point of that event: Nexus had been there. After so many decades of his presence, the public had accepted that they lived with one more form of natural disaster than they used to. No one was especially happy about it, but just like hurricanes and earthquakes, their feelings weren't a factor in the equation.

The pale, bald man sitting alone in his lab watched the screens. It would have been better if no one had gotten involved; he'd wanted to see how long his invention could keep the capes guessing on its own. That was an ideal test, something in a controlled environment; he'd run too many of those. Field data was essential, and until it had crapped out, his system had sent back quite a useful amount. If nothing else, he now knew his devices could buy at least twelve hours.

All in all, a successful beta-trial. The only hiccup had been those idiots kidnapping someone from the guild. While not a member himself, this man knew of them quite well. A bit too blunt for his tastes, they tended to be more chainsaw than scalpel, yet that didn't mean they could be ignored. That was the thing about blunt objects: they often hit quite hard. Another factor to keep track of, though he wasn't worried. There had been more elaborate schemes in the past, albeit not many; this was well within his capabilities.



Behind him, an odd, lumpy device began to chirp and squeal, soft lights cascading across its surface. Turning away from the television, his slender fingers ran across the mechanism, drawing out more horrifying noises. Perfect timing. With phase one wrapping up, he needed to turn his sights onto what came next.

Neither the guild nor the AHC had any idea what they were truly in for.



Tori sat in a conference room, coffee and chips in front of her, trying to stay calm. So far, things had gone smoothly. Lodestar saved Tori, bringing her to the AHC, where a doctor was waiting to check her over. Dr. Miraculous didn't have the most professional name; however, she'd quickly inspired competence. Professional, observant, and with an impeccable bedside manner. After some thinking, Tori put it together. Of course the AHC's doctor was good at helping people coming fresh from traumatic situations—that would be almost exclusively what she dealt with.

Afterward, Tori had been offered a shower and fresh clothes, which she accepted. There was no reason she could come up with to explain why she would rather stay in her dirty ensemble. While the jeans and shoes were fine, Tori was slightly less thrilled about the “Ridge City Loves the AHC” t-shirt they'd provided. This felt like the sort of thing the rest of the guild wouldn't let go of if they caught sight of it... not that she didn't have bigger concerns at the moment.

Soon, someone would walk in this room and try to coax a story out of her. What she said next, or didn't say, would determine how successful the rescue truly was. It was only a good one if the whole guild got out clean. Tori couldn't let them down, especially after they'd shown up to save her. Setting her resolve, Tori was braced for any lawyer or interrogation specialist to step through the door.

She was somewhat less prepared when the glowing form of Lodestar strolled in, however, nearly choking on a chip. There was something about her, a sense of power that announced itself even as she humbly walked over to the table with a gentle smile. It didn't escape Tori's notice, even through her starstruck shock, that Lodestar shut and locked the doors.

In a way, Lodestar seemed stranger here than she had in the warehouse. Seeing Lodestar mid-rescue, busting through a skeezy lair—that felt right. Watching her amble through a conference room was bizarre, like seeing a T-Rex napping in a park. Or Fornax working in an office, she reminded herself. Tori had seen past the curtain; she knew the legends were more than their reputations or powers. Still, that was easier to remember when the reputations weren't quite so looming.

“Tori, if you're up to it, there are some questions I have to ask you.” She took a seat, her inherent glow lighting up the chair's dark material.

“However, before you answer, there's something that needs to be said. I know you don't want to talk to us, and I know why.”

Having been prepared for hours of probing, verbal bait, and linguistic trickery, Tori felt dumbfounded as Lodestar dropped that kind of bomb so casually on the table. Was she bluffing? No; Ivan had warned Tori that anyone on the Champions' Congress could be clued in on her secret.

“That puts us in something of a pickle, you see,” Lodestar continued. “There are questions it is vital you answer. Pieces of information that will help us strengthen our detection abilities and figure out how this gang blocked us. I can't risk you lying about anything and tainting that intel. Whatever else we might disagree on, I think we're together on one point: neither of us wants to see this happen to someone else.”

Tori's hand tightened into a fist involuntarily. Finally out of danger, she was starting to process everything that had happened, a rush of emotions, many of them anger-adjacent, whirling up at merely the thought of her ordeal. The legendary cape had hit the money there: Tori definitely didn't want to see anyone else experience this.

“Here's how I'd like to proceed,” Lodestar continued. “We both know there are things about your life that you're not comfortable sharing with me. Today, they are irrelevant. You were stolen off the street against your will. I'm not here to treat you like a criminal. If, in the course of this debriefing, we hit one of those areas, just stay silent. That's fine. It's a right the legal system offers even to those under arrest, which you are not. All I ask is that you not lie to me. Whatever you say to me, make it the truth. Can you work with that, Tori?”

When Ivan told her Lodestar was both more predictable and more dangerous for her lack of subtlety, it hadn't exactly made sense to Tori, but there had been larger issues demanding her attention at the time. Now,

sitting across this table from her, Tori understood. Lodestar was, despite her insane power, disarming. There was something in the gentleness of her tone, the sincere concern in her eyes, that made Tori feel inherently safe. A great quality during a rescue, less optimal for an interrogation. Nevertheless, this was happening, and Tori couldn't repress her own curiosity about the living legend.

"I think I can live with that. Do you mind if I ask you a few, too, as we go?"

"Of course. I'm sure you've got so much you must be wondering about. But may we start with your version of what happened? Studies show that the sooner we do these, the more accurate the recollection tends to be." From a hidden pocket on her costume, Lodestar produced a small device. She set it on the table, pushing a button and getting a red light.

Interesting. So she'd left the first part of their talk off the record. Tori mulled that over as she began her tale. The kidnapping part she skimmed through, seeing as that had apparently been on the news. Most of what she relayed was factual, going through the way she'd been treated by her kidnappers, her bathroom arrangement, and so on. It wasn't until she got to Nexus that Lodestar looked worried, though she said nothing, allowing Tori to continue spinning her yarn. Only in the last bit of the chronology did Tori have to skip some details, recounting her wild run from the monsters without mentioning she'd been living fire at the time. The tech room, Tori relayed as best she could, mentally pulling up the way the machines had been interconnected. Much as she'd have loved to take them apart herself, the acid had done too good a job. If Professor Quantum could get information out of that rubble, he deserved it.

"You've been through quite the ordeal," Lodestar said at last. "Not many people would have kept such a cool head on them during that kind of situation."

"Benefits of having practice. I saw the importance of staying calm during the attack on my office a few months ago." Tori had kept that one locked and loaded, an explanation for her competence and a reminder that one of their own was her friend.

Lodestar nodded. "Yes, I just finished speaking with Cyber Geek, actually. He wanted to be in here, you know, but I felt it was best to keep things private until we had a better idea of your condition. Plus—" Her eyes darted to the recorder for a split second "—he hasn't had training for this

yet, and we wanted to be sure to collect your testimony as soon as possible. I have more questions about the computer room where I found you, but why don't we take a brief pause so you can rest your voice."

Reaching over, she tapped the recorder once, ending the red light's blaze. "If you wanted to ask me questions of your own, this is probably the time."

"You don't want your answers on the record?"

"Tori, I have no idea what you're about to ask. Some of what you might know is technically classified as Top Secret, though honestly, after the whole Apollo kerfuffle, I'm not sure where a lot of that stands. Point is, unless it's germane to the kidnapping, it doesn't need to be on that tape."

That hadn't occurred to Tori, but Ivan had made it clear the government was the one who set the villains free. Heck, even the tool they'd used for it, the Orion Protocol, had a clandestine-sounding name. Lodestar made a good point, though. They were working at an information disparity. Tori probably wasn't going to change that, but she might be able to figure out what tidbits were off-limits.

Double-checking the recorder out of habit, Tori sat up a little straighter. "I guess my first question is what *do* you know?"

"A lot less than I can prove, which might as well be your organization's motto," Lodestar replied. "Pertaining to you, I know you're a meta-human, I know you're wading into very dangerous waters, and I know the man you call uncle has no blood relation to you. Though my understanding is he's still been something of a mentor."

Okay, so, as it turned out, Lodestar knew quite a damn bit. She'd even called him a mentor, was that word a coincidence? No, she was laying it out just like she had the entire time. At least Tori didn't have to worry about slipping up and accidentally revealing too much. Outside of the rescue, anyway.

"I've got one for you now, and we can leave the recorder off," Lodestar said. "The New Science Sentries told me what happened, that you learned their civilian identities. I'm sorry I have to ask this, but forewarned is very much forearmed in these cases. Did you tell the gang who they are?"

With some relief, Tori realized that this was one where she had nothing to hide. "Nope. We didn't really get into much grilling. I mostly just kept pissing the head guy off until he stormed away. I haven't told anyone their secret."

That earned her a surprised look from Lodestar. “Anyone?”

“Not a soul. I like it when people respect my privacy, so I’d be an ass not to do the same.” Tori realized she was supposed to be asking questions, but the sudden enormity of the opportunity had struck her. This was someone who’d been around since the mid-eighties, had seen untold powers and threats. Someone who knew the guild leadership in ways Tori likely never would. There was so much to ask, yet her tongue found itself dazed with options. Scrambling for something to keep the talk moving, Tori fell back on a question that had nagged at her for quite some time.

“Why does my uncle trust you? I get why he respects you—as the only person to ever put him down, that gels with who he is. But you threw the man in jail, yet I’ve never heard him say a single bad word about Lodestar. The exact opposite, in fact. I know you helped talk him into the... work release program. I know you showed him that pic of his kid. But this is more than that. He trusts almost no one, yet has total faith in you.”

From her slightly glowing mouth, Lodestar let out a perfect whistle, like the start of a songbird’s symphony. “Wow, you really jump right into the complicated stuff, huh?” She leaned back in the chair, staring up at the ceiling and beyond, looking to a mental destination where Tori’s eyes couldn’t follow.

“Here’s the thing you have to understand about Ivan and me.” Evidently, Lodestar really had killed the recorder, as she was comfortable using real names. “For a good stretch of years, he and I were in our own power category. Both of us unbeatable, untouchable most of the time—until we met each other.”

There was a flicker in Lodestar’s eye, hinting at so much more than what was escaping her lips. Still, even the words were precious, so Tori listened closely.

“We were the strongest metas in the world. Back then, we didn’t even know for sure who was more powerful. The only ones we had to battle, to truly test ourselves against, were each other. For a long time, we kept up the dance; he knew how to stay off my radar, but we usually ended up in brief skirmishes. Until we finally had it out for keeps and discovered who the strongest really was.”

While it might have been Tori’s imagination, she thought Lodestar seemed almost sad about that. Perhaps she’d enjoyed the mystery, too.

“I can’t tell you why Ivan trusts me—that’s his choice. All I can say is that we know each other in a way you can only know someone you’ve fought against, and alongside. For years, we were among the few constants in one another’s lives. The crook I couldn’t catch, the cape he couldn’t beat. I’m not sure if that made us friends, nemeses, or a combination of the two, but it made us *something*. That would be my guess as to why Ivan trusts me as superhero. I hope it answers your question.”

“And then some,” Tori replied. “While also raising countless more. Not going to be greedy, though. That was a lot. We can do more debrief stuff.”

Lodestar lowered her eyes back to the table, focusing on the moment at hand. “Before we go down that road, there is one more thing I’d like to broach with you. Just something to consider. You have shown adaptability, intelligence, and resolve over and over, without factoring in your less savory efforts. This is the second incident you’ve publicly been in, and last time, you helped one of our most promising new members. Between your mind and your powers, you make a potent threat. The kind that could be dangerous, when properly nurtured. If you were any other person, I’d be making this offer, and I see no reason not to give you the same opportunity.”

Flaring up a tad brighter, Lodestar met Tori’s eyes, the full force of her gaze nearly causing the younger woman to blink. “Tori Rivas, have you given any thought toward using those talents for good? We could use someone with your abilities at the Alliance of Heroic Champions.”

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## Chapter 34

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“Look, I know we were using a lot of double-talk here, but I’m kind of... spoken for, in that department.” Tori wasn’t even certain she’d heard Lodestar right, and she damned sure didn’t know how to respond to that sort of suggestion.

“Two types of people join your current organization,” Lodestar replied, utterly unfazed. “Criminals who were caught then won their freedom, and the ones getting educated before they make any major slipups. I know you’re in the second group, and even the crimes I suspect you of are fairly minimal. People make mistakes. What matters more is their ability to grow and learn from them. You wouldn’t be the first player to change teams, especially so early on.”

Could that be true? Sure, she’d heard of a few former crooks turning over a new leaf—just no one on the guild’s level. But a new costume and codename could easily transform plenty of metas into functionally new people. In the end, Lodestar was probably telling the truth. That seemed to be her style. This was a point to make certain she understood clearly, however.

“I’m not even sure that would be allowed,” Tori said weakly, trying to get her bearings.

“Oh? I’m pretty sure one of the first rules in your code is not to go around messing with superheroes. Especially ones with the AHC. Which is what you would be if you made the switch, Tori. Yes, it’s allowed by the code’s own wording. Even if that wasn’t the case, you could still come over. I’ve made *my* position on that policy clear to your leadership.”

She paused, looking Tori over more closely. “I think that’s all we need to say on the matter for tonight. You’ve been through a lot, and there’s still more questions to ask, so let’s leave this question there. I don’t need or expect an answer right away; these are the sorts of choices you should fully consider.”

A glowing hand moved toward the recorder, then stopped. “There is one more thing. Part of why I’m comfortable making this offer to you is that you haven’t crossed my major lines. There’s a reason the guild largely preys on other criminals; not even I can protect people from their own actions. Tried at one point and things went *bad*. Keep that in mind. Because if you bring civilians into the equation, you bring me in as well. Don’t cross that line unless you understand the consequences.”

“I get it. Keep the fight on the playground, it’s fine. Spill into school, and the teacher becomes involved.”

“Your school needs more involved educators,” Lodestar told her. “That is the thrust of it, though. Are you ready to get back to the debrief?”

“Honestly, at this point, that sounds like a nice break.”

Tori hadn’t planned to say that any more than she expected Lodestar to laugh: quick and melodic, like the sweet refrain of a lovely song.

Chuckling to herself, Lodestar hit the record button. Time to get back to business.



It was a shame they couldn’t take any of the physical materials from the cloaking system, but Xelas had managed to come back with quite a bit of data. She’d copied the entire software system, along with a few stored schematics, as well as scanned the actual tech itself. Some parts of the machinery had still been cloaked; however, all in all, she and Wade had managed to assemble a reasonable mock-up on the holographic display table in front of them.

He was in his normal clothes, simple and professional, the sort one might expect a quaint local librarian to wear. Except Wade was a billionaire genius supervillain, and there was nothing placid or quiet in his expression as he looked everything over. Someone had bested him on the field of technology. Maybe only for a day, but it had still happened. While he’d



accepted long ago that Professor Quantum and Tyranny were peers at or past his present level, being thwarted by some new upstart grated on his nerves. Especially since they'd taken one of his people in the process.

As he looked over the holographic facsimile, formed of data and sculpted light, he zoomed in on a section. Some of this equipment was too homegrown to puzzle out the purpose of with just his eyes, but the power unit was using an electron looper, a standard tool for powering massive equipment off standard wall outlets. Wade had seen and made more than he could count through the years, and something about this one was off.

"Xelas, check the southern east quadrant, the power source. Why run nineteen thelmian micro-rings for stabilization when a simple boron buffer does the job better and cheaper?"

"Better question, where did they even find thelmian ore? Records show only a few meteors of it hit in the late fifties, and the majority of that wound up with the AHC or private collectors. Oh, guess they robbed a collector—answered my own question." Though she was smiling, there was a focused gleam in her eyes as she followed Wade's gaze. "Interesting. I just ran a full check through my archives, and this actually used to be the standard way to make an electron looper. Professor Quantum invented the boron buffer in the mid-sixties, and it soon became the standard, but before then, this was the design."

Old tech, using materials that were supposed to be scarce. Wade mentally laid out the situation once more. A gang with tech lightyears beyond their grasp kidnaps a woman off the street, one who was famously saved by the New Science Sentries. They call out that same team publicly, keeping the woman hidden to force the capes' hand. Had the New Science Sentries complied, they'd have been walking in to a trap full of advanced weaponry. It couldn't be a coincidence that everything centered on a new version of the world's first superhero team, yet the tech in use was dated.

"The good news is that I suspect Tori's kidnapping really was a coincidence. All of this seems to be about Professor Quantum's old team. My money says that someone he pissed off is out for payback."

"Good news because it isn't our fight?" Xelas seemed confused, if not disappointed.

The malicious gleam in Wade's eye put any doubts she had to rest even before he spoke. "Hell no. This is absolutely our fight. We've needed something to focus the guild members on, a task that keeps them busy

without risking too much AHC wrath. After one of our own was taken, they're all itching to show some dominance. No, that's good news because it means neither side will be paying us much attention. With Tori saved, they'll expect us to go back to minding our own business."

The metal fingers danced along his shoulder, finding their way to the back of Wade's neck, where they spread out and wrapped around, gripping gently. Xelas pulled him in closer, only inches separating them. "And what will we really be doing?"

"Waiting for the right opportunity to strike."

"You do know how to talk to a gal. Well, this one, anyway." She kept the kiss brief. Much as she loved Wade when he went on the warpath, they still had a lot of work to do breaking down her data. Big talk didn't mean a damn thing if they got caught with their pants down again.



By the time they were done talking, Lodestar having asked about every detail and tidbit she could regarding the cloaking system, Tori's head was starting to feel fuzzy. Her brief nap in Lodestar's arms hadn't been a full rejuvenation by any means, and the day's compounded stress was causing pain above her temples.

To Lodestar's credit, she soon noticed and wrapped things up, leaving the caveat that Tori might be called back if they thought of new questions to ask. All things considered, it had gone well. Tori managed to avoid implicating herself or the others, and she'd escaped without being seriously wounded. The best she could have hoped for, really.

As they were about to leave the room, Tori realized that there would be others waiting to see her. Donald, certainly, and probably the New Science Sentries as well. They would be concerned, caring, and way more than she could handle at the moment.

"Is there a private exit? I'm... I need some time before I see anyone."

"Of course." Lodestar smirked, a strangely mischievous feature on her face. "Close your eyes."

Normally, Tori would have balked, or at least asked some clarifying questions. It was a demonstration of her exhaustion's growing dominance that she merely did as instructed. A brief feeling of wind and weightlessness

washed over her, and when Tori opened her eyes once more, she was at the AHC's entrance—a massive door with various tourists and workers streaming through. The first floor was a museum dedicated to superhero exploits, so it saw quite a bit of foot traffic.

“Moving at those speeds will make you nauseous if your eyes are open, unless you have practice,” Lodestar explained from behind her. Already, the crowd was looking over, though none of them had even a glance to spare for Tori. “Go on ahead. I’ll sign some autographs to keep everyone distracted. Your ride is waiting for you.”

Tori looked out the sliding doors and realized there was a familiar form outside on the sidewalk. Amidst a sea of chipper families and excited kids, the stoic man standing stock-still stood out like neon. It was odd to think she could be so happy to see that dull expression, but as her eyes fell on Ivan, Tori felt something inside her relax, something she hadn’t even realized was tense.

Much as she wanted to rush out, Tori took her time. Almost against her better judgment, she looked back to Lodestar. It could have been Tori’s imagination, but she was almost sure she caught Lodestar sneaking a few looks out the door as well. Since meeting Ivan, she’d assumed his odd reverence of Lodestar was one-sided; after today, she wasn’t quite so sure. Whatever this complicated mess was, it certainly appeared to be going in two directions.

With the crowd occupied, Tori made her way forward, out the sliding doors and into the summer’s fading heat. She made her way down the smooth entrance lined on either side with topiaries carved into the shapes of famous capes, and walked up to the man who was a legendary villain, and one of the few people who’d proven he gave a real shit about her.

“How do you feel?” Ivan asked.

“Tired. Numb. Drained.”

Scared. Guilty. Lost.

His hand landed gently on top of Tori’s head, heavier than she remembered. “Let’s get you some rest. You’ve more than earned it.” A moment of hesitation, his hand almost pulling away. “I am very glad you’re safe, Tori. We were all worried, but we also had faith you’d pull through.”

There was no way to say why—it wasn’t a particularly emotional thing to say—but that was Tori’s breaking point. Picturing the guild, her friends, her life, knowing how close she’d been to losing everything. All the fear

she hadn't let herself feel, the horror of what she'd done to Deacon, the helplessness of being taken against her will, it all came crashing down at once.

Tori buried her face against Ivan's chest as she wound her arms around him, hugging him with all the strength her body could still manage. She wanted to weep, to let everything out, but Tori wasn't practiced at letting her guard down to that extent. Instead, she just held on, her whole body shaking. Here, she finally let herself feel at ease. Nothing could get her. Nothing could hurt her. She didn't even have to hide parts of herself like she had with Lodestar. Tori was safe.

It took her a few minutes to realize that Ivan was gently hugging her back. A few minutes more, and Tori realized people were staring, not that she gave any semblance of a shit. But sooner or later, they'd recognize her, take some pictures, and the media cycle would begin anew. She gathered her composure, the shakes dying down as her breathing stabilized.

"Sorry. Probably not a reaction befitting somebody like us, huh?"

"Tori, you have nothing to apologize for." It was an occasion where Ivan's blunt tone worked to his benefit, making it clear he thought the very notion ridiculous. "You did well, better than anyone had the right to ask."

"Yeah, sure, but I gotta stick the landing, right?" Tori finally managed to pull away, releasing her grip on Ivan. "Can't get weighed down by all of this."

This time, Ivan was the one who initiated the hug, though he kept his short. "I'm the one who owes you an apology if you think that. There's something I've owed you for a while now, and when you're ready, I hope it will help you get some clarity on that front. It's something I should have told you already, something I avoided because it means dredging up the past."

Together, they walked away from the AHC's headquarters, Ivan taking her to a spot where Tunnel Vision was already waiting with a portal. It was hard to beat the guild in terms of treatment options and general safety, both of which were very relevant for Tori. The plan was to get her some food and rest, letting her return to the world at large when she was ready. Ivan hadn't expected to add a story in there, but holding Tori as she shook was too familiar for him not to see the need. It was time to pay what he owed her for reaching graduation.

It was time to tell her about the origin of Fornax.

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## Chapter 35

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No aides or other members of the AHC would be walking in on Professor Quantum in this room. He'd established a private laboratory at the inception of the entire organization, a place where he could perform delicate experiments without worrying about interruption. Security had been upgraded—by him—regularly until he'd moved the bulk of his work to the island of Vomisa. Even with years of lapses, it was fortified enough for the moment's task.

Laid out before him was a simple cube. That's how it appeared, at least. According to the recovery reports, this had been one of the things found in a pile of pink goo, surrounded by melted parts, yet it showed not so much as a scratch. The tech who recovered it had been puzzled, but Professor Quantum understood as soon as his fingers touched the smooth metallic surface.

Keltrine was a synthetic metal he'd once thought to have world-changing properties. Inventing it was one of Professor Quantum's earlier projects; exposing various natural materials to different meta-elements had resulted in many strange new compounds, and Keltrine was the most promising. Many of the early Science Sentry gear had made use of the seemingly indestructible metal, until they discovered its weakness.

From his pocket, Professor Quantum produced several packets of sugar taken from the breakroom. He sat down across from the cube, helping himself to a bottled water from the small refrigerator built into the desk. As a man who often got lost in his work, nutritional elements had to be kept on

hand. He'd tried to get other labs on board with bathroom buckets as well; however, that suggestion had so far failed to take hold.

Taking no care or measurements, Professor Quantum tore into the first sugar packet, dumping it into the water bottle. He did this six more times, until the water had turned milky. Finally satisfied, Professor Quantum emptied the entire container onto the cube, slowing pouring it out to cover every section. As soon as the liquid hit, the cube hissed and bubbled, turning to a crumbly, sand-like substance. For as durable as Keltrine was, they'd learned fighting Wrath-Taffy that sugar created an immediate, destructive chain reaction. It was Professor Quantum's introduction into the unstable world of working with these strange new elements and the unusual side effects they produced.

The larger issue at hand was that anyone was able to create this particular bit of Keltrine in the first place. Only a few had figured it out when it was in use, one industrious tinker making an entire tiny army before the flaw was discovered. Most who knew the creation method were dead, and even the Mini-Murder Marquis was long retired. There was only one way to interpret this cube's existence: it was a message for him. Hidden in something they couldn't miss, and made durable enough that it would be near impossible to destroy.

As the water bottle reached its end, the last of the cube crumbling, a shiny new surface came into view. This one was metal, as well, though it merely shone in the sugar-water rather than melting. Unconcerned about mundane worries such as poison, Professor Quantum picked up the item, rubbing it clean and examining it carefully.

A commemorative pin. 1955 Original Edition, one of the first superhero souvenirs to ever be sold. Of course, that was largely because meta-humans had only been around for a few years. This was a big moment, for the world and Professor Quantum. These marked the launch of the Science Sentries, the world's first superhero team, precursor to the League of Metas. All five members stood there, staring at the camera, their likeness captured in the metal circle.

Last Professor Quantum had noticed, these sorts of items retailed for hundreds of thousands of dollars among collectors, which made it all the stranger that this one had been defaced, quite literally. Of the five, only Professor Quantum and Rex Reverb were still recognizable. The rest of the team's faces were scratched off. No coincidence that he and Rex were the

only ones still presumed alive—that was obvious. But if the implication was that the sender had been responsible for the deaths, then that was ludicrous. They'd fallen years apart and to very different threats.

The message was clear, at least. Someone was targeting him, someone with a shocking knowledge of his prior work. The cube and button were clear hallmarks of the past.

For a moment, a single horrible moment, he thought of the mad-grinning skull, then put it out of his head. As a man of science, he knew better than to spend his time chasing ghosts. Focus on the current threats rather than ones already beaten.

To that effect, he wondered if he should give Rex a warning. He was on the button, too, and would make a compelling target to someone sending a message. After a moment of contemplation, Professor Quantum decided that perhaps Rex would be more useful in the dark. If they put a protective detail on him, he'd be the perfect bait—acting completely natural, drawing out potential attackers. It was risky, true, but that was the life of a superhero. He was sure Rex would understand, or, barring that, was sure he wouldn't care if an old teammate was mad.

Professor Quantum was a man who concerned himself with results. It wasn't as if they had the option to sit back and wait, anyway. This was an opening move. He'd seen far too many not to recognize one on sight. Whoever had made this cube wasn't remotely done. But their next move wouldn't come quite so easily.

Now that Professor Quantum knew there was a game afoot, he intended to crush everyone who dared challenge him.



“What’d they tell you?” Chloe asked, red-eyed on the edge of the sofa.

“She’s safe and sound, just like the reports are saying.” Beverly sounded deeply relieved, and that was with some effort to keep her tone neutral. Thuggernaut’s rundown was quick and concise, but hit all the points he knew she’d be worried about. After wrapping up the rescue, they’d been taken home immediately. With capes buzzing about, any time in mask was dangerous. Since then, she’d just been waiting with Chloe to find out how the rest of Tori’s morning went.

“Lodestar scooped her up, she did a few hours at the AHC making a report, and now, she’s resting somewhere safe. My contact wasn’t sure when she’d be back, probably a day or so, but physically, Tori came through fine. We’ll have to see how hard it hit her upstairs.”

“I just feel so bad. First, she ends up all over the news for being saved by Tachyonic, then this. Tori hates attention, and now, she’s going to get it nonstop.” From her side, Chloe pulled out a spiral notebook with a pen jammed in the top. She flipped through several of the pages, idly chewing on the pen’s cap as she mulled them over. “I keep thinking there’s something I can do. Unfortunately, the closest I’ve gotten is ‘Better seen than heard,’ which is both gross and the opposite of what Tori needs.”

While Beverly wasn’t sure this effort would bear fruit, she also couldn’t dispute that Tori was going to loathe the limelight. Worse, this wasn’t just some quick news story anymore. There hadn’t been a kidnapping like this in years upon years; adding in her existing fame momentum and the fact that the story appeared to end in a Nexus slaughter would only make the story more salacious. This might no longer be a thing they could simply wait out.

But that was getting far too ahead of herself. First, they needed to help Tori the person, then they could worry about her elevated profile.

“We’ll figure something out. In the meantime, I’m going to make a grocery store run. At the very least, we can have her favorite beers and snacks when she gets home.”

Chloe’s eyes lit up. “Great idea! If you don’t mind getting ingredients, I can make a nice comforting soup.”

Mentally flashing back to Chloe’s most recent stovetop culinary attempt that wasn’t grilled cheese, Beverly could still taste the half-cinders passing as pork chops. Mercifully, the logistics of their situation made for an easy out. “That’s a lovely idea, but why don’t we wait until we know when Tori will be home? No sense in buying ingredients only for them to go bad.”

She hustled out the door before the conversation could go any longer, in such a hurry that Beverly nearly crashed into the sizable form of Austin, who’d clearly been walking down to their apartment. Reflexes saved her from a full collision, bringing her up a few inches short of his chest, causing a quick backpedal.

“Sorry about that. Should watch where I’m going.”



“Please no, it’s my fault.” Austin looked nervous. He was fidgeting in place, actively avoiding looking into her eyes for too long. “I... I didn’t even have a good reason for coming over. I just wanted to apologize in person, if she’s ready to see anyone. We promised protection, and then, only a few days later, completely failed to keep Tori safe. I don’t expect her to forgive us, especially since it’s our fault she got targeted in the first place, but she deserves an apology all the same.”

It took Beverly a few seconds of mental gymnastics to put everything together. Right; Austin would have heard from the AHC that Tori was released. Since this was her home, he’d expect her to be here, resting and recovering. It was tempting to sell that delusion, pretend that she was being a shut-in, which wasn’t much of a stretch for Tori, anyway. Too complicated, she quickly realized. Better to stick close to the truth, if she had to deviate at all.

“I respect that sentiment, but Tori isn’t here. After everything that happened, she’s staying with her uncle. Family support during trying times and all. She’ll be back when she’s ready.”

“When that time comes, may I impose on you to let her know I’d like to talk?” Austin’s eyes, still largely avoiding Beverly’s, seemed to be sinking floorward the more they talked. “Though I understand if Tori has no desire to see any of us again, and I will respect the choice. My duty to apologize is not her obligation to hear it.”

For a huge guy with legs like phone poles, Austin looked curiously unstable. His first few weeks in Ridge City didn’t seem to be going to plan, for sure. Messing up their debut, getting put on protection duty, then fucking that one up on a national-story level—much as Beverly held a grudge against the AHC and Professor Quantum in particular, it was hard to pile all of that onto the nervous guy before her. Plus, she needed to lay a little groundwork for Tori. Otherwise, these four would be up her ass the minute she got home.

“Look, this is my opinion and should not be construed to reflect how Tori will feel, but I don’t think the kidnapping is entirely on your team. No one expected some gang to try a street snatching. As far as you knew, Tori was going to work. Following her would have been weird, bordering on harassment. When it happened, did you do everything you could to get her back?”

“Sadly, yes, and what we could do was nothing.” His jaw tightened, and for a moment, the nerves vanished. She saw the face of a leader angry at his own limitations, forced to the sidelines while others did the work. Sometimes, her parents wore that expression when talking about their harder missions, the darkest tales they’d share with their kids. Wanting to help, and lacking the power to do something was hard. Being on the sidelines while people they cared about *were* in the fight was magnitudes worse, apparently. “We spent our night out on the streets, keeping the peace. Useful work to be sure, just not helpful to Tori.”

Beverly checked her watch. After a night spent out as Bahamut, hanging around a Detroit warehouse and helping Pseudonym kill Nexus’s pets, she should be exhausted; however, the thrill of combat still had her blood pumping. It would be a little while before she could sleep. May as well put it to good use. The more she could do to ease Austin’s guilt, the less he’d try to bother Tori with it. After the rescue, Beverly had been feeling somewhat useless herself; this was finally one way she could help.

“All night fighting, huh? With a body like that, disregarding any meta-influence, I’m guessing that means you’re famished. Have you tried the Mono-Mart’s counter-service yet? They make a mean breakfast burrito, and I’m heading over there on a grocery run, anyway. You can tag along, if you like.”

Just like that, the nerves were back. For a moment, she thought he might spit out gibberish; his tongue seemed uncertain of its intended use as his jaw twitched within his mouth. Beverly had other shit to do with her day, so she threw him an excuse to move things along.

“After all, my roommate was just kidnapped. Might not be safe to walk out there so early alone.” Even without her powers, Beverly had mace, a taser, and a lifetime in a family with a strong Marine service history. There was no mugger on this block she couldn’t handle, but Austin didn’t know any of that yet. If it got him out his head and moving, that was all that mattered for now.

It not only worked, it worked so well that Beverly was caught off guard. The shift was immediate, like someone had thrown a switch. His nerves vanished, spine straightened, and his gaze became direct. Whatever personal failings Austin had, they weren’t shared by Agent Quantum. Once upon a time, she’d have found it strange. That was before the guild; before

she understood the roles people played, and the way they could shift between them.

“You’re absolutely right. It would be my honor and pleasure to escort you on your errands.”

“Dial it back a notch, big boy.” Beverly patted him on the shoulder, noting how solid it was. “We’re just going on errands and breakfast. Why don’t you tell me about your fake job on the way?”

Though he didn’t slip back into his less confident posture, this question did cause his eyebrows to knit in confusion. “My fake job?”

“Yeah, your cover story. What you tell people when they ask you what you do, since you obviously can’t tell them the truth.” She looked at Austin, who stared right back at her, until realization finally dawned. “You don’t have a *cover* story?”

“In the initial plan, we weren’t going to be interacting with normal people as ourselves very often,” Austin admitted. “It’s possible we were undertrained for this type of scenario.”

That was putting it shockingly light. They were going to blow their identities again any day now, and the next time, it might not be to a room of people with incentives to keep quiet. Worse, if people realized Tori was living a few doors down from the New Science Sentries, context be damned, she would get a fresh dose of fame. Possibly end up linked to them forever in the public’s eye.

Which meant that if Beverly wanted to protect her friend, she had to help a team of capes blend in. Or find a new apartment. Given their specific needs and the current Ridge City real estate market, aiding Austin seemed like the easier task, even if she’d have preferred the latter.

“Okay, new idea. We figure out some fake jobs for you all while getting breakfast,” Beverly declared. “Which you’re paying for. I don’t do consultations for free.”

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## Chapter 36

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Her new room had a window. That would have been impossible at the old base where they'd been tucked away in the middle of the city, hiding themselves in plain sight. One of the upshots to moving the guild's operation out of Ridge City was the change of limitations, not to mention the scenery. Volcanic lair or not, Tori had to appreciate the amazing view of the island and the glittering ocean that stretched beyond it.

The sun sat low on the horizon; she'd been asleep for most of the day. Looking down, Tori realized with a small trickle of embarrassment that she was still wearing the AHC t-shirt Lodestar had provided.

It was a passing thought that floated away as her eyes went back to the window. Looking at the ocean was pleasant, soothing—a vast improvement over the images replaying in her mind. Being chased by the spitting monsters was scary, getting kidnapped had filled her with rage, but it was Deacon that kept popping up the most. She could still feel the flames of her arm torching his throat as it slid down, still see the horrified pain as the fire caught. There was no regret in Tori—she'd done what she had to. Yet the images kept coming. Killing Rust Tooth hadn't hit her nearly this hard, though perhaps it was because it was a mere blip in a day of mad chaos.

Even that recurring memory was better than the choice Tori could feel resting on her shoulders. What next? When she left this lair, she'd be facing serious decisions. Her life had changed, and not in the fifteen-minutes-of-fame way. This was too big; it wouldn't flare out overnight. In a few years, sure, she might be able to get back to some manner of normalcy, but her

face and name being all over the news would stick in people's minds, especially given the context.

Staring out at the lapping waves, she considered staying here. The facilities were all top-tier, she'd never have to hide her face or her true identity, and everything she needed was on this island. Tori frowned, a sight she was able to catch in the window's slight reflection. This place might have everything Hephaestus needed, but not Tori. She had plans and ambitions beyond the guild, the kind she'd have to be in the real world to execute. Besides, Beverly and Chloe were counting on her to help cover rent. She wasn't ready to say goodbye to that life quite yet.

She contemplated a shower and a change, but a loud rumble from her stomach skewed priorities. Whatever waited down the line, Tori at least knew her next move today. Leaving her room, Tori realized a moment after the door closed that she still hadn't change t-shirts; however, her capacity for caring had already maxed out. It wasn't worth the time to go back.

The halls were largely empty as she made her way through, arriving at the room number Ivan had left for her. It opened to reveal a sizable area, probably meant to be a conference room, though she doubted there was often so much of a spread. Sandwiches, stew, seared fish, and a few dishes Tori didn't recognize—all of it fresh and steaming. She dove right in, not even caring that the room was otherwise empty. If anyone in the guild wanted her dead, they'd pick a more direct method than poison.

After a minute or so of eating, Tori saw Ivan enter. Truly Ivan, no Pseudonym mask, and certainly no Fornax one. Just the unassuming middle manager who was easy to overlook. How was he so good at keeping a low profile, especially considering what Fornax was like? Maybe it was just a matter of practice; he'd been at this much longer than her.

"I hope you like the food. Made it earlier today, and had Dabbler throw on a seal to keep it fresh until you arrived."

"Guess the room also sent an alert." Tori managed to get down her mouthful of turkey leg before speaking, but it was a photo finish. "Or were you hanging out in a hallway, waiting?"

Ivan said nothing at first. He headed over to the drink area and fixed himself a simple cocktail of vodka mixed with ginger ale. Once that was prepared, he pulled out a beer and set it down next to Tori, who popped the cap immediately. "How are you feeling?"

The food-shoveling paused momentarily. Tori could feel the memories trying to rise up, perhaps bringing her meal with it, and she halted them through sheer force of will. This was not the time to lose herself. “Like, I really don’t want to talk about it. Not right now, at least. I think I need some time to get my head around everything.”

“After what you’ve been through, that is a completely reasonable sentiment,” Ivan said. “If you’d like to push our talk back and stick to less serious topics, that is fine as well.”

“No.” The word came out a tad too fast and strong. Tori tried again, taking more care. “No. I could use something else to think about. Different place to put my mind. Plus, I’ve been waiting months for this; no take-backs now.”

Despite Ivan’s neutral expression, he was actually quite conflicted. Tori was clearly spinning; he’d seen it happen to younger metas more than enough times to recognize the signs. He wasn’t entirely sure this story would make things better. It wasn’t one he cared to share often, and never in circumstances like these. Ultimately, upholding his word seemed to be the best choice, though he planned to keep an eye on how Tori was coping at various points in the tale.

“The first thing you have to understand is that you and I grew up in different worlds,” Ivan began. “I don’t mean that I’m from another dimension or universe—I’m from this planet, this realm, same as you. But it wasn’t always like this.”

His expression hardened, memories flashing already. “You live in a world with a backstop. A ceiling. A limit on how bad things can get, called the Champions’ Congress. Professor Quantum has one of the keenest, hungriest minds, paired with cutting-edge meta-human knowledge and potent abilities. Quorum has over a thousand people working in perfect unison in that head of his, seeing every situation from more angles than entire organizations could hope to. And of course, there’s Lodestar. The strongest meta. The true superhero. Together, they represent a functionally unstoppable force. Look at your own kidnapping; the people who took you had cloaking equipment beyond what most world governments could fashion, and it wouldn’t have even bought them a full day before the AHC arrived. Against any threat, they have the mind of Professor Quantum, the insight of Quorum, and the power of Lodestar. Every villain in this world, every criminal and thug, every goon and crook, understands that if they

make too much trouble, that's what is waiting for them. The sky is the limit, because to rise that high means catching their attention."

"I once asked some of the council members who would win in a fight: us versus the AHC. They said it would be a pretty even match," Tori interrupted. She didn't necessarily doubt Ivan, but conflicting data was something that itched in her brain.

"You didn't ask *me*." Ivan paused, mentally doing some math. "But unless you somehow stole some councilor time at our relaunch, you must have asked that during your apprenticeship. Before Lodestar was back."

Part of Tori wanted to rebel at that idea, that one cape could turn the tides so greatly as to change the answer entirely. Except, when she thought back to Ivan's breakdown, to when he returned to being Fornax, the way he'd batted around the AHC's top capes like toys, Tori could understand how a truly powerful meta might swing things in a fight. Especially one that could lead on the front lines, inspiring her allies to battle.

"My point is, this world has limits. No fleet of Destrucoblimps will try to take over Utah, because the AHC will put them down. No random genetic monster can wipe out a city, because again, the AHC will stop them."

"There were capes before the AHC," Tori pointed out.

"Yes. Ones that saved the day many a time. But never without risk, and often not without loss. They were not unbeatable—that is the very point I'm driving toward. Here, there are no *real* worldwide threats, because in your heart, you know anything that dangerous would draw the capes' attention. Most beings who are smart enough to actually be a threat to the world are also capable of seeing the odds stacked against them. It means fewer people ever try to take things that far because they'll never succeed. And most realize it. That creates a different world than one where power is up for grabs, and the strongest can claim it."

Some of the food settled heavy in Tori's stomach. "That was your world?"

To her surprise, Ivan slammed the rest of his drink, went back over to the bar, and fixed himself a double. When he spoke again, there was an ache in his voice she'd never even caught a whisper of before. "That was our world. Mine and the others'. There were lots of organizations out there chasing meta-powers, some with science, others through training, and a few

that went the magical route. A cult favored that last option to great success: the Order of the Final Dawn.”

The crack that appeared along Ivan’s glass was telling—largely because Tori knew how much emphasis he put on self-control. For him to slip already didn’t signal she was in for a cheerful story.

Making his way back to the table, Ivan set his cracked glass down. “I never knew my parents. None of us did. Some were bought. Some were stolen. Most were unwanted. That’s what I’ve pieced together through the years, anyway. Back then, it didn’t matter. Nothing mattered, with one exception: combat. From my earliest memories, we were fighting. We fought for meals, fought for clothes, fought one another even for the simple right to use a toilet. The cultists would use magic to keep us healed afterward, but they always let the pain linger. They considered it to be an excellent teaching aide.”

Lifting his hand, Ivan made a fist. Such a simple gesture, yet Tori could feel the power contained within, even across the table. “Much as I hate them, I think they might have been right on that front, a fact that makes me despise them all the more.”

“I’m sorry, Ivan.”

He smiled at her, though there was no joy in the gesture. “Thank you, but I fear the tale has only just begun. That was my early life, you see. Nonstop scrapping, until they began to educate us on how to fight properly. Trainers were brought in, men and women I now suspect were killed as soon as they finished imparting their lessons. Creating monsters was all the cultists cared about, that and their dogma. I doubt they would have taught us to read, write, or speak if not for the weekly ceremonies chanting from the holy scrolls. That was life, until the year we turned ten.”

The story petered out momentarily as Ivan looked into his drink, making no move to touch it. “I had a pair of friends back then. Thick as thieves—pardon the phrasing. I was a little better than them at fighting, a touch of natural talent and a growth spurt giving me a slight edge. Vlad was the smartest of us all; he had a clever streak too wide for his own good. More than a few fights he won were through trickery and deception, though he got good at an old-fashioned low-blow, too. Our third member doesn’t have a name, for reasons that will become clear. He was... soft. Kind. Not made for that world. Although, in hindsight, I wonder if perhaps it was



more impressive that after ten years living like that, he still managed to hold on to some spark of gentleness.”

In one gulp, Ivan downed his second drink, however he made no motions to fix a third. Whatever he’d been gathering courage for, it seemed they’d arrived.

“At age ten, we finally realized what we were doing there. That was when we had our first Trial of the Worthy. That day was the first time our numbers were halved.”

Tori had thought she was bracing for where this would go, but her appetite faded suddenly as realization set in. “They killed half the kids?”

“No. We killed each other.” Ivan made a point to meet her eyes; there could be no miscommunication on this front. “They put us in rings of magical, closing fire. Ones that could burn you for hours without leaving so much as a sear. Neither could leave until one was dead. Supposedly, the assignments were done randomly, but to this day, I never believed that. Pitting me against one of my only friends seems too cruel, even for fate. Only humans sink that low.”

Ivan didn’t need to say more. The outcome was obvious by the fact that Ivan was here, rather than killed at age ten. Still, he pushed on. Perhaps he wasn’t able to stop upon reaching this point; it certainly didn’t appear to be a topic he had much practice dealing with.

“He begged me not to hurt him. I didn’t want to. I held out for so long, but burning alive without rest or relief... he cried as I choked him. Never tried to fight back, though. Just kept staring at me, staring as he went limp, staring as the flames faded, staring as they dragged his body away. I can still feel him, decades later. His gaze, his tears on my hands, the softness of his neck. To this day, I don’t know why Kristoph didn’t try to take my head the moment we met.” Ivan took a long, steadying breath, his hands pressed against one another. “After that, after I killed one of the two people in the world I loved, they named me. Because I had earned one, in their eyes. I had taken the first step toward their great prophecy, become a contender for their highest honor. That was the day I got the name Ivan. If Vlad’s moniker didn’t give it away, we were named for warriors, kings, and conquerors.”

Breaking his hands apart, Ivan forced them onto the table. “I wanted to tell you that the first kill with your own hands is always going to leave a scar. You feel like you should be unfazed, but what happened to you today threw all of us for a loop when it was our turn.”

“I killed Rust Tooth during the Ridge City Riots.”

“No, *Hephaestus* killed Rust Tooth. Today, Tori killed someone. Even if you don’t know why that feels different, it’s okay that it does. What you’re experiencing is normal. How you proceed is up to you, but know that it does get better with time. For as horrible as that story I just told you was, my life went on. I’ve found people and moments that bring me sincere joy, something I could have never imagined inside that pit.”

Tori shoved her plate away; she’d had her fill. The words felt true, even if it was hard to believe them just yet. There was a lot to think on, but that would come piece by piece. In the meantime, she was eager to keep the discussion going, especially since there was a major point yet to be covered.

“Is that how you became Fornax?”

A dark chuckle slipped Ivan’s lips, close enough to Fornax’s mad giggle that she felt a sliver of nervousness before reassuring herself with his controlled expression. “That day was the start, both literally and metaphorically, of me becoming Fornax. Just the start, however. You see, every year, there was a Trial of Worthiness. Every year, our numbers shrank. Sometimes, we fought three times. Sometimes, a single match was enough. All in service of their prophecy—the coming of the being with many names. The God of Endings, the Onslaught of Death, the World-Razer, a bunch of awful shit like that.”

“No one ever told them less is more, huh?”

“Clearly,” Ivan agreed. “Not that it mattered. The name wasn’t the point. Getting it here was. According to myth, its body was too great to enter our realm, so only its soul and power could make the journey. To exist on our plane would require a host, a form with which to use all that terrible strength. That was the purpose of our raising. They wanted to breed a mighty body, strong and honed, to serve as their great monster’s vessel. When the last Trial of Worthiness ended, I was the one left standing. I was the last survivor.”

A flicker of a pause, like he was steeling himself. “I was chosen as the host of an entity whose sole purpose is to destroy this world.”

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## Chapter 37

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Half-watching the television screen out of the corner of his eye, Rick clicked on some programs hidden in a folder buried deep in his computer. A nice, law-abiding kid shouldn't have any of these sorts of programs—bootleg hacking software bought in internet back rooms and from a skeezy guy outside a computer repair shop. Rick didn't fancy himself competent enough to get into anything truly secure, nor would he want to. As a boy with dreams of working at NASA, he understood there was a line between childish mischief and serious crime that it was important he not cross. Besides, he hadn't gotten this sort of software because he wanted to hack the school, or break into a bank's system.

No, this was a personal project, one he'd been working on for a few years now. A secret from his friends, and especially from his family. What would Beth say if he shared his findings? As though he could even call what he was looking at "findings" in the first place. It felt more like insane conspiracy theory than actual hypothesis—one that Rick would have dismissed, if every new bit of information he found didn't support the suspicion.

It had all started with a simple school report on genealogy. Getting their mother's information was easy—a long line of professors, laureates, and other highly documented careers made it possible to see the heights of their family tree. Dealing with their dad's past was another matter, in that he didn't seem to have one. It was no secret that their father had been abandoned as a child. He didn't talk about the experience in depth, but it

was one he shared with his own kids, if only to explain why they had no relatives on his side.

That was where it should have ended: an in-depth report covering one half of his family, and a sad story on the other. More than enough for a good grade. Except, Rick was his mother's son, and once a project had his mind, he was loath to let it go so easily. So he'd kept digging. Hunting for foster records, old school photos, any sort of documentation from his father's childhood. When that had come up dry, Rick had shifted gears to young adulthood, searching for any signs of Ivan Gerhardt prior to meeting their mom.

Nothing. Oh, there were documents saying he'd existed—rental receipts and leases—but it was only a paper trail. Rick had gone so far as to search a database of old photos of capes in action, hoping to spot Ivan in a background of the city where he'd supposedly lived. Even that, he could have brushed off... until he'd decided to test it.

Just a drive for ice cream. That was the pitch, a simple request. An excuse to get them driving around an old neighborhood of Ivan's, one where he'd supposedly lived for years. Jamming the GPS was easy enough—like most parents, Ivan didn't exactly have a stellar grip on technology. Such a simple test, and yet, once his guidance was gone, Ivan had immediately become lost. Despite having an address, and being in an area he *should* know by heart. Shops might change, but street signs weren't so malleable.

That was the day Rick's silly side project had gone from a flight of fancy to a sincere suspicion. He'd begun to dig deeper, even taking a few real risks, yet it all circled back to the same result. On paper, Ivan Gerhardt was and always had been a perfectly normal, almost boringly mundane, sort of man. In reality... Rick wasn't even sure that was his father's real name.

His working theory was a witness protection program, that Ivan had seen something he wasn't meant to and gone on the run. Occasionally, when Rick really thought about it, his mind would drift to the scent of the ocean, though why that was he couldn't begin to guess. Today, however, he was less concerned with Ivan himself and more so with Tori, the nice coworker of their father's they'd once met who'd been all over the news. She'd also had a surprising lack of personal information leak out, despite being plastered on every channel. Given that she was one of the few people

outside of family and existing friends he'd seen Ivan show interest in, Rick suspected that she might be part of the same witness program.

Getting into Vendallia's real systems were well beyond what Rick could manage, back-end programs or not. Luckily, he'd long ago learned to chase the human element rather than a purely technological one. People often didn't think to clear out the file logs on their scanners, which hosted a treasure trove of useful information.

Wielding his programs and a few passwords lifted from his father's office, Rick made his way onto the server, clicking on the scan log files. For the most part, it was boring stuff. Evidently, they must use something more secure for financial or proprietary information. All he was finding were low-tier HR forms, including several well-deserved complaints of an employee microwaving fish. Then he caught it: Ivan's name finally present on a document. Rick enlarged the image, leaning in to peruse the small lettering.

He read it twice more before finally leaning back and clicking a print button. As the pages appeared, he turned toward the screen once more, looking at Tori in a new light. Who the hell was this woman? And why was their father, a man who'd spent his whole life claiming to have no known blood relations, filing an HR declaration form listing Tori Rivas as his niece?

Rick still didn't have much to go on regarding the mystery of his father, but this was the first major clue in years. Whatever Ivan's secret was, Tori Rivas could be the key to unlocking it.



"Last time we talked about this, you said your powers came from eating a god." Tori didn't mean it as an accusation—she had confidence the two tales would line up eventually. It was more her trying to put the story together in her head, connecting dots that were still too far apart.

"It's the best word I have for what happened," Ivan replied. "I was eighteen during the final Trial of Worthiness. So were the few who remained. My last fight was a lot like my first one, in that I was against an old friend. Thankfully, Vlad and I hadn't been the same since I killed our

third, and tricky as he could be, I was the better fighter. When it was over, when I'd killed the last person I grew up with, the cultists came."

There was a detached tone to Ivan's voice; he was powering through, getting the facts out without slowing to deal with all the inherent emotions that came with such a topic. Tori made no requests for details. She understood the need to run through some discussion points far too well.

"We went to a chamber I'd never seen before. I was stripped, covered in arcane symbols and oils, then placed in a warded circle when the ceremony began. After they started chanting, I fell away from the physical world, into the place where minds and souls dwell. How long I was there, I truly have no idea, but the next thing I felt was *it* breaking through."

Ivan shook his head, glancing at the empty glass with a dash of desire, followed by self-imposed restraint. "That monster was everything they'd wanted. Massively powerful, with an appetite for chaos that can never be sated. It exists only to destroy. Which is what it tried to do. Devour me, my soul, my essence, and then take over my body to use as a vessel."

"Clearly didn't know what a stubborn bastard you are," Tori interjected.

"You joke, but you're not far off from the truth." A smile was forming on Ivan's face. Dark, twisted, and cruel, yet a smile all the same. "The cultists made a mistake, you see. Only the body was meant to be tempered and prepared, not our minds. By placing us in that crucible, they forged our wills—forcing us to face constant death sharpened our desire to live. Their monster was expecting a soft-headed morsel ripe for the plucking. Instead, he met a man who had fought with every drop of blood in his veins to make it that far, with no intent of letting his hard-won life slip away. The thing about the realm of minds is that willpower is what matters most. You can't take muscles or magic in there, only your strength of self."

Now that she had the missing piece, Tori could see how the story components fit together, though she said nothing yet. Ivan clearly still had more to get through.

"That devouring of the soul thing is a two-way street. Magic tends to balance like that. In order to cross over, the monster also had to become vulnerable. Turns out, he didn't want this body quite as much as I did. It was still one of the hardest fights of my entire life, mind you—one I'm not sure I could ever win again. But I did manage to triumph, wolfing down that massive intruder, making his power my own."

Ivan's smile sharpened further at the corners. "You should have seen the looks on those cultists' faces, for the brief instant they still had heads."

"Payback?"

"For a childhood spent living as a caged animal, forced to fight the only people I cared about? No. Not even close." His expression hardened, eyes looking back into the past. "Not even the next few years felt like enough revenge, and I spent those keeping a promise to wipe out the Order of the Final Dawn."

"Here I thought a man seeking revenge was supposed to dig two graves," Tori said.

"Oh, I dug a *lot* more than two. Or rather, I would have, if there was ever enough left to bury, and I cared." Ivan took a moment to compose himself, idly nibbling on a chip from the corner of Tori's massive buffet. "I gave the Order of the Final Dawn exactly what they'd wished for: a destroyer. A god of death. They just didn't realize it would be coming for them instead of the world."

"About that..." Tori trailed off, trying to think of the best way to broach this topic. Knowing now what she did about Ivan's power, there was a fairly salient concern to address. "Are we to the point that explains what happened with you and Apollo? Because that's one I'd really like to have a better handle on."

Something flashed on Ivan's face... shame? He turned away quickly, leaving Tori with only a glimpse to work from. His voice, however, remained steady and constant. "That came much later. The thing about devils is they always leave an escape clause in their contracts. I have the raw, destructive magical power of the god, but little knowledge on how to use it. In all these years, even with tutoring, I've only managed a few consistent spells. Some aspects come easier; the host body is meant to be nigh indestructible, and I have a natural aptitude for drawing out the physical magic. But I'm nowhere near as dangerous as what this body could do in the intended owner's hands. Hence why the option to ask for a little help is always there. A bit more influence, in exchange for greater power. One way for the devil to worm its way back in."

Turning her half-eaten turkey leg around on the plate, Tori considered the situation. "I'm kind of surprised you took that option. Doesn't seem like you'd want anyone else having control over you."

“For a very long time, I didn’t. Until there was a fight that had to be won. That’s another long story, though, one I doubt either of us has the energy for. You don’t need to worry about it, anyway. If I ever do truly lose myself, Lodestar will stop me.”

“Are you sure she can? I get that she’s the strongest out there right now, but you just said the full-power version of you is a big step up. That might be too much even for Lodestar.”

“It isn’t,” Ivan replied. “Understand something, Tori. I know it might seem silly, the amount of deference I show to her power, but it is wholly warranted. As one of the few people to see Lodestar’s true abilities, I know how strong she really is. But as one who loves science, you can simply turn to the data for proof. I am not especially unique. If one has access to multiverse tech, it’s possible to look out into the mirrors of our worlds and see how many things turn out consistently. Some events appear locked, going the same route nearly every time. Others are malleable, with shifting outcomes. One thing that is constant, in essentially every world: when the world is at risk, Lodestar wins. Even if it costs her the ultimate price, she wins.”

Now *that* kicked Tori back a few mental feet. “Hang on, there are worlds where Lodestar dies?”

“Of course not. In so far as we were able to detect, no one has ever successfully killed a Lodestar. But the power is a mantle. A mask, like the ones we wear. Lodestar never dies; however, the person filling that role is vulnerable. If she goes too far into her own power, or loses her will to fight, there’s no way back. It moves on, shifting the mantle to a new wielder. Like if your meta-suit could find a new wearer after you had a heart attack in battle.”

“Sounds terrifying,” Tori admitted.

Ivan nodded. “Which is why I would greatly prefer *not* to directly cause the death of the current Lodestar, the woman who helped me gain my freedom and my family. One of the many reasons I place such emphasis on self-control. Lessons my apprentice took well, based on her performance tonight.”

For the first time in several minutes, Tori touched the beer to her lips. She’d wanted something to think about besides her kidnapping, and on that front, Ivan had more than delivered. Bad as her own upbringing had been, she at least hadn’t been locked away and forced to kill for survival. The



memories of Deacon still kept flickering to the surface, but they weren't as powerful now that Tori knew it was okay to be rattled. Even Ivan still visibly felt the weight of his first kill, and she certainly wasn't going to fare better than someone who'd had decades to deal with it any time soon.

"Thanks. For the compliment, for sharing, and for never letting me feel like I was in there alone. My big question now is: what's next? I can't go back to being another face in the crowd, not for a while, if ever. But I don't want to run and hide here on the island, either."

"Let me ask you this: if there was no fame or kidnapping to deal with, where would you be?"

"Work. Or barring that, home with my friends. Maybe working on my suit—though honestly, this last day has me thinking that it might be time to break ground on some new tech. Things that are portable, that I can carry with me at all times, just in case... of... huh." Abruptly, Tori stood from the table. "I actually think I know what I want to do. Can you get me a meeting with Wade in a couple of days or so? And yes, I used that name on purpose."

"That'll be up to Wade's schedule, but you'll get an audience when he has a window," Ivan said. "Dare I ask what sort of idea you're pondering?"

It was Tori's turn to smile, though hers was more mischievous than terrifying. "I think I just hit on a way to turn this kind of fame into an opportunity. Figured it was only right I give our leader the first bite at the apple."

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## Chapter 38

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For the most part, it was a quiet drive home. Tori had spent a few hours at the volcano lair, taking advantage of the privacy and lack of distractions to work on some initial designs and inquire into material availability. The guild's network of underground suppliers had been diminished by their public outing, but not wiped out completely. While some of the more exotic components might take a bit, there was plenty to get started on what she considered the more simplistic options.

By the time Tori crossed back over to Ridge City via the country club and caught a car back to her apartment, it was the dead of night. Even the bars were closed as they rolled along the quiet streets. Tori watched the light posts go by, ignoring her body's desire to shiver when they passed isolated stretches. She wouldn't give this new fear any purchase. Her life was too dangerous to be afraid of something as simple as walking down the street. It helped to remind herself that, if she'd been willing to accept the consequences, escape had always been an option. Next time, she wouldn't have to make that choice, though. Next time, she'd be ready as Tori.

As the car pulled up, she noticed a figure waiting in the shadows not far from her building. Too public for a fellow villain, oddly shadowy for a cape. Maybe someone had decided to take a run at her already, while she was a hot commodity? Tori expected to feel no more than exhausted at the proposition, but an ember of rage quickly took light. This shit was not going to fly, and if she'd learned anything from the guild, it was the importance of sending a message. Maybe some broken bones and pulped testicles would give the next dipshit pause.

No sooner was she out of the car than the figure was moving, however. The shock of copper hair gave away the surprise seconds before she reared back for a punch.

“Fucking hell, Donald! I thought you were another damn kidnapper.”

“So you were coming toward me?” Donald emerged fully into the light, clad in his old civilian clothes. Slacks and a wrinkled plaid button-down made him look like the easier nighttime target. Once upon a time, that would have been an accurate impression, too, but months with the AHC had affected Donald. From the width of his shoulders to the way he stood straighter, being a cape was changing him. Into what, Tori suspected she’d have to wait to find out.

“Sorry, I’m not here to scold. I just wanted to make sure you were okay. And that you got home safe. And to say that I’m... I’m sorry, Tori. You’re my friend, you helped me when I needed it most, and I couldn’t be there to return the favor.”

Occasionally, she wondered if it was wise, having a friend on the other side of the line. Donald was a liability, someone who could turn on her once he learned the truth. The more she saw of Fornax and Lodestar’s odd dynamic, the more Tori had begun to suspect that these things might be inevitable. Ultimately, it didn’t really matter. Donald was her friend, and even if this appearance was creepy as shit, it obviously came from a place of concern.

“Hey, buddy, little perspective: the motherfucking Alliance of Heroic Champions, including all three members of the Champions’ Congress, worked together to save me as fast as they were physically able. I know you’re having a good debut year, but in no way do I hold you to a higher standard than Quorum or Professor Quantum.” Tori crossed the rest of the distance between them, gently taking his hand. “No one expects you to save the world yet, Donald. Just keep doing the best you can with the power you’ve got. That’s all anyone has the right to ask.”

He met her eyes for a long moment before glancing away. “Sweet lord. I came out here to apologize, scared you instead, and now you’re comforting *me* after a day of being kidnapped.” Donald sighed, shaking off some of his reticence. “I wanted to tell you not to worry, that we’re going to make sure you’re covered—not just at home. We’ll—”

“Hard pass.” Tori cut him off, but didn’t let go of his hand quite yet. She didn’t know how it would go over, but she could always elevate to a firm

sell if the amiable approach failed. “Donald, for a multitude of reasons, some of which will become clear soon, it is vital that the AHC *not* put a protective detail on me. The New Science Sentries can stay, since they’re already moved in and I don’t hate the idea of our home being protected, but in no way, shape, or form do I want capes on my tail every time I leave the house.”

“Tori... you’re a target now. You’re famous. Even if it won’t actually hurt the AHC, there are people who will go after you because they think it makes us look bad. I’m not trying to scare you more; I just want you to understand that it’s dangerous. You’ll need protection.”

“I’ll have it.” Tori released Donald’s hand, jamming her index finger into his chest. “But not from the Champions’ Congress, not from the normal patrol capes, and yes, Donald, not from you. This is my life, and if the AHC can’t respect that, then you’re not giving me much more agency than those kidnappers did.”

Though Donald looked like he’d been slapped, he made no counterargument. “I don’t want to force myself into your life. If that’s how you feel, I’ll stay away. I’m sorry, I just wanted to make sure you were safe.”

Before he could turn, Tori grabbed his shoulder. “Hang on there, drama king. Cyber Geek doesn’t have permission to tail me, but my friend Donald is still welcome to come around. Just call first, and leave the shadow skulking to the criminals. Do pass what I said on to the capes. I’m serious about that.”

Despite smiling as she stopped him, Donald’s smirk faltered at her order. “I’ll pass the word along. But... well, I don’t really have the authority to tell everyone else what to do.”

“That’s fine. I have plans if it comes to that. So long as you can respect the boundaries, I don’t hold you accountable for whatever else the AHC does.” Tori dearly hoped Donald remembered that sentiment if the tables were ever turned and he learned about her organizational ties. “In fact, let’s do lunch next week. By then, I might have something fun to show you. Until then, I think one of us has a city to save.”

It didn’t escape Tori’s notice that Donald hung around on the street until she was through the door, but he was gone by the time she looked out the window again, so they seemed to have reached an understanding. Tori was feeling quite pleased with herself as she ascended the stairs, mentally

replaying the conversation and unable to catch any major slip-ups or reveals.

Her good mood evaporated as she arrived on her floor to find Kyle leaning against the stairwell, a pile of empty test tubes accumulated by his side. His eyes were fluttering open as she put her last foot onto the wooden floor, the creaks calling Kyle out of slumber's clutches.

"Hrugh?" Kyle shook his head, slowly moving to stand. For her part, Tori kept on walking, making a beeline for her apartment. She felt like she'd made good progress, only to hear her name from a few feet away. Damn speedsters. "Tori? Tori!"

"Oh holy fuck, I do *not* have the energy to do this twice." She whirled around, catching Kyle by surprise. "It's fine that you didn't protect me; that's not your real job, and we both know it. I don't care that you weren't there at the rescue; nobody was going to do a better job than Lodestar, anyway. You don't owe me an apology or an explanation. I'm the penance case you got stuck with after a fuckup, and no one actually expected any of this to happen. We good now? Because it's a few hours from sunup and some of us have had a real shitberg of a week so far."

It was only as she spoke that Tori truly looked at Kyle, noticing the sway in his posture and his wavering vision. By the time she was winding down, Tori had a hunch, but it wasn't until he finally spoke that she got confirmation.

"You... do not like us." Kyle seemed almost relieved by the words, slurred though they were.

That definitely sealed it: Kyle was drunk. A quick look over at the test tubes gave Tori a working hypothesis, one that was easy to check. "Did you get liquored up on some kind of hooch for people with super-speed metabolism?"

Her response was Kyle lifting a finger to his mouth and blowing out sloppily, in what was probably supposed to be a "shhh" gesture. "Don't tell the others. This is such an Ike move."

"Is that why you're drinking in the hall? Didn't want your friends to find out?" Now that she knew he might not be out here for her, Tori's annoyance level sank considerably. A drunk night during a hard week was hardly something she had room to get judgmental about.

"Started out at the roof pool, watching the stars." Kyle looked around, knitting his brow in concentration. "Crud, when did I get down here?"

“No idea, but let’s get you home.” Taking his shoulder, Tori guided Kyle down the hallway and the short walk to his actual door. She moved to knock, but it slid open before her fist was even fully raised.

To Tori’s surprise, it was Ike waiting at the door, looking up at the both of them. “Thanks. I was going to peel him off the floor within the hour if he didn’t come in soon. Come on, you bossy cock, let’s get you some water.”

Ike led his taller teammate inside, laying Kyle on the couch, then teleporting to the kitchen to grab a bottle of water from the fridge. Tori watched him work, realizing that this was the first time she’d been around Ike or Presto without a constant torrent of noise pouring from his mouth.

“Does this happen a lot?”

“Maybe twice a year,” Ike replied. “Austin is the team leader, but Kyle’s got a lot of responsibilities that weigh on him. Every now and then, it gets to be too much and he tries to go wild. Once caught him listening to old techno music on the beach, attempting to get drunk off stolen wine coolers. Much of a pain as Kyle can be, all that uptightness comes from a desire to be good at this job, to be a real superhero. Occasionally, that thought makes him more tolerable.”

It was strange to see Ike so matter-of-fact, a complete swing from the crass personality he usually donned. Unnerving, too, because Tori hadn’t really considered him past that depth. She’d taken his surface level for the real thing, a mistake no self-respecting villain could rightfully excuse. Perhaps this night was a happy accident; better to know about a threat than to be caught unaware.

“What’s your role, then? Austin’s the leader, Kyle is the clear second. Seems like you and Ellie would have parts to play as well.”

“I’m the scapegoat. She’s the tits.” The words were delivered almost neutrally, save from a touch of fire in Ike’s voice toward the end.

“Wow. Sorry, I thought the ‘piece of shit’ thing was more of an act. My bad.” Tori looked toward the door, but Ike teleported over, offering her a water bottle as well.

“You think I picked those roles?” Ike asked. “Don’t ask a question you don’t want answered. What I said was the truth. You could find any number of metas with adequate powers to fill my spot. I’m on this team because no one will ever really like me, so if something ever goes wrong, I’m the one who takes the heat. I’m not being cute, or funny. This is the job I have.”

She accepted the water, eyeing Ike uncertainly. Tempting as it was to head home, learning more about the capes down the hall was probably an opportunity worth pursuing. If she was stuck with them anyway, understanding their inter-team dynamics couldn't hurt. "Why take a job like that?"

The question earned her a genuine laugh out of Ike, a harsh bark that trailed off quickly. "Look at me, Tori. I'm short, not personable, and at my best, I've got a plain face. Despite a power that kicks all kinds of ass, I'm never making it to the big leagues on my own. Does playing the scapegoat role suck? For sure. Is it also my only chance at touching true greatness? Hell yes."

"And Ellie?"

Ike's face darkened for a split second. From his pocket, he produced a cell phone, cycling through the pictures until he stopped on one of a younger Ike and a dark-haired woman smiling on a beach. Actually smiling, in Ike's case. There was something familiar about the woman, too, though Tori couldn't quite place it.

"That's before she made the cut. Before the 'profile enhancements' deemed necessary for someone representing the New Science Sentries brand."

Holy shit. Now that Tori looked closer and squinted, she could see the resemblance. It wasn't easy, though. Cheeks, lips, chest, hair, everywhere she looked, there were only hints of the Ellie she knew now in the picture. The woman had practically been rebuilt with plastic surgery, despite how natural she still looked. An advantage of Professor Quantum's tech, no doubt.

"She agreed to this?" Tori asked.

"It was a chance to be on the New Science Sentries, a team founded and funded by the world's first superhero. Yeah, she took the deal. We'd spent years trying to earn the opportunity. Eleanor became Ellie, who then took the title of Plasmodia. Or did you think her costume's cut was a coincidence?"

The more Tori saw of Professor Quantum's team-building methods, the gladder she was that there were other capes in the Champions' Congress. If Beverly's family history hadn't already clued Tori in to the fact he was a bastard, this certainly would have tipped her suspicion.

“I suppose she had her reasons, just like you did,” Tori said at last. “As for me, I need to rest. Take care of Kyle, and try not to let him drink in the hallway like that. I’ll see you all around.”

“Something tells me you’ll be seeing us all sooner than you might think.”

She was back into the hallway as she heard Ike’s words, and by the time she turned to investigate, the door was shut once more. Too wiped to sincerely care, Tori trekked down the rest of the hallway, turned the lock, and stepped inside.

After days that felt like years, Tori was finally home.



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## Chapter 39

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The high-pitched whine pattered out, echoing through the office's vast space for several seconds before fading completely. Setting up shop in a hidden cave lair had many privacy benefits, but the acoustics weren't anything to sneeze at, either. A pale, gaunt hand scratched out the final bits of the message as the sound turned into a ringing in the ears, before finally transitioning into a persistent memory of a noise.

It was the final transmission he'd expect until the arrival neared. Once they were moving, non-emergency communication would be too risky. Even this had required years of research to create specialized concealment equipment, and worked largely because few even bothered to scan for these sorts of signals. The longer he could keep his presence, and plans, a secret, the greater his chances of success. Time had taught him patience, a very useful skill, especially when one played a game that ran for decades.

On this occasion, patience was hardly required. About a month. That was how long he had until the party could properly begin, based on travel calculations. One month to get everything in order. Much of the groundwork had already been laid; being thought dead for decades made it possible to work easily unseen. The big players were accounted for, as they had been since the plan's initial conception. It was the newer, smaller fish that represented the capacity for chaos. Some chose to ignore fresh metas, believing the true challengers aged into their power. But the world was not a fair place, and some were born with more strength than others. Being experienced, he'd seen too many undone by such hubris.

The next step was securing fodder. Lozora's contacts were of a specific type, those with established reputations. It was essential to have a known element approach the other criminals; they weren't exactly the openly trusting sort. However, numbers still counted for quite a lot, especially where the game of distraction was concerned. Dealing high-tech weapons to various criminal outfits was a dual-pronged tactic: it not only allowed him to test designs before the big day, it gave him an in with the unsavory enterprises.

This task was best handled by someone with no past, origins, or true identity. Moving from the repaired communications array, the man ambled over to a drawer, producing a small square box. Popping it open, he thumbed through the array of IDs for his various identities. Some were fresh; others had been in use for decades, building up legitimate histories. Those were suited to other tasks. Today, he sought something fresh.

A pair of Ws jumped off a card at him, and he smiled. The names were left up to chance, so one must have come out that way by coincidence. Or, perhaps, serendipity. Either way, the search was over as he pulled the card up from the ranks of its brethren, promoting it to a position of usefulness.

"I suppose I shall be Wendel Worthington, then. For a few weeks." Wendel took the card over to his computer, where the identity's other information could be researched. A name with alliterating Ws might not mean much to most people; however, for Wendel's purposes, it was a perfect moniker. A tribute, in a way, to one of the only other people who'd managed the same accomplishment.

There were, after all, only so many people who Professor Quantum *truly* hated.



After the long week she'd had, Helen was aching for a few minutes of relaxation. Penelope was still sleeping, other members of the AHC were keeping the world safe, and she'd just finished a long night flying the skies. The sound of hot water pouring into her bathtub was like a siren's song of rest.

While she didn't really feel pain outside of serious attacks from major metas, Helen could still carry tension. Her back especially was ready for

some treatment. She paused in the kitchen long enough to grab a mug of coffee and warm it with a quick blast of her thermal-breath, then headed for her sanctuary. Unfortunately, before she could reach the peaceful palace of porcelain, the phone rang. Not her home phone, of course. Life could never be that simple.

From the pocket of her robe came Helen's AHC-issued device, packed full of technology. It wasn't quite on par with the Quantum Utility Tool she kept on her as *Lodestar*, but was far less conspicuous, as to the outside observer, it was little more than a phone like countless others.

"What's up?"

Quorum's voice was waiting for her—another bad sign. "Quite a great deal. The world is restless, and Captain Bullshit has just unveiled another exhibition. Concerning you—however, there is specific business that needs addressing. On a rescue mission last night, we had a team suffer heavy civilian losses. While they still saved a great many, the pain of their failing is undeniable. They need to see *The Grove*, and historically, you liked to be contacted in those situations."

Standing in the door of her bathroom, Helen stared at the soft steam steadily rising from the tub, practically forming a hand and crooking a finger to invite her in. There were others who could do the job, who had been doing it for years while she was gone. Except it wouldn't be the same. When the speech came from the strongest meta, when *Lodestar* said that nobody could save them all, the newer superheroes listened. Twisting the knob, Helen killed the water and popped open the drain, letting her planned moment of peace go swirling into the sewers.

"Let me drop Penelope with a sitter, and *Lodestar* will be there."



It was a surprise to wake up and find snow falling from the sky. For one thing, the season was still late summer. For another, snow wasn't usually blazing purple and electric blue in color. Lastly, Tori was pretty damn sure snow didn't turn into flowers when it landed. True, they died after a few minutes, but it still had the effect of letting Tori look out her window and see Ridge City caught between a blizzard and a jungle.

“Oh good, you’re up. I was coming to get you.” Beverly pushed the bedroom door fully open, having already turned the knob.

“Is this something we should be concerned about?”

“Nah, the news says it’s just a Captain Bullshit exhibition.” Making her way across the room, Beverly joined her friend by the window. “I’m not great with meta-history, but he can change reality, right? With a power like that, he kinda sticks out.”

“As I read it—and this was in an article from years and years ago—the consensus is that he can reshape reality, but only to create what he deems to be art. Not sure what the exact term was—I think he called his style ‘absurdist creative expressionism,’ assuming that isn’t just word-soup. Never much of an art gal.”

The two of them stayed like that for several minutes, watching the multicolored snow fall and coat their city in a sea of flora, which died and was replaced in fairly quick succession. One thing was apparent, however: no one would be driving in this. A car might make it ten feet before becoming overgrown, and that was being more than a little generous.

“The city invoked a meta-holiday, so most businesses are closed,” Beverly supplied, her own eyes tracing the empty streets. “Chloe is home all day, and I’m ahead of schedule on work. After what happened, if you want to be alone, I get it, but if you wanted to have some company, we’re here for that, too.”

A reassuring hand landed on Tori’s shoulder, almost causing her to flinch. After a moment, she let herself relax. Or at least as relaxed as she was capable of being.

“I know you well enough to guess you might want to shove past the whole kidnapping thing, and if so, then we can respect that. Just know that if you do decide to talk about it, I’m around.”

“Thanks,” Tori said, her voice stiff despite her best efforts to soften it. “Maybe once I’ve had a little time. For now, I need to feel like a normal person, you know? Just for a day, leave all the other stuff on the sidelines and rest.” Burning as her ambitions where, Tori could also feel her own exhaustion, the kind sleep would do nothing to fix. She needed to reenergize, and drudging up that recent horror-show wouldn’t help.

The hand on her back clapped her once before removing itself. “Good time to want normality, though. We can turn this into a snow day: watch winter movies, make hot chocolate, enjoy a mini winter break.”

Pressing her hand to the window, Tori could feel the heat coming through the glass. If anything, it felt warmer than it had lately. Maybe flower-rain warmed things up, since normal rain cooled the temperature down? It was hard to put too much logic into this sort of thing; reality had literally been momentarily warped, so making sense was largely optional.

“I think we might want to go the other way with that. By noon, this whole place’s AC will be fighting to keep up.”

Beverly followed her lead, a momentary blip of surprise on her face as she felt the warmth. “Huh, not a bad point. Okay, so... beach day? Make margaritas in the blender, go make use of the rooftop pool before fall really sets in?”

Ordinarily, Tori would have happily chosen a day working in her garage lab, but this week was anything but ordinary, even by supervillain standards. A day with her friends sounded like just the right change of pace. Some normality to balance out all the extra crazy she’d been dealing with of late.

“I’ll tell Chloe once she’s out of the shower,” Beverly offered. “You get dressed. We’ll figure out a game plan.” Beverly almost went to leave, before stopping herself. “Look, we don’t have to talk about this right now. I just want to tell you so you don’t think I’m springing it on you later: I sort of ended up inviting our neighbors over later this week. Austin and I ran into each other. We got food, and by the end, I’d somehow offered some basic socializing lessons so they can stop blowing their cover so often. Don’t feel obligated to attend by any means—I got myself into this—but also, please be aware we’ll be hosting capes on Sunday.”

Although even twelve hours ago, that might have been of greater annoyance, Tori wasn’t quite so bothered by the idea as she’d expected. Seeing Ike and Kyle’s more vulnerable sides had offered useful insight into their personalities and the team’s dynamic. If they were going to be her protectors, she should probably understand their limits. And if they were going to be Hephaestus’s enemies, she should definitely know their weaknesses. Either way, Tori always held to the belief that more information was a boon, and this sounded like exactly the sort of scenario where such tidbits might be spilled.

“Let me know once the details are pinned down. Can’t make any promises, but I’ll try not to leave you on your own to deal with them.”

“I appreciate it. Given their current track record, I can only imagine what sort of state secrets they’ll accidentally reveal,” Beverly said. To her, that was probably a joke, though Tori wasn’t so sure. “Get dressed. I’ll get things started on our snow day, but for sun. Sun-day? No, crap, that’s obviously a day already. I’ll figure it out by the time you’re done.”

Beverly marched out, momentarily more concerned with her naming dilemma. As for Tori, she took her time getting ready, starting with a short shower that was closer to boiling than hot, the sort that a human would have shrunk from. It felt good to be in her own shower, getting ready like it was another day heading to Vendallia. Most of the time, Tori fit well into her extraordinary life, but on occasions she too needed the comfort of routine.

Post-shower, getting ready was a simple affair, with no cumbersome work clothes to bother with. A simple t-shirt and shorts would see her through until it was time to head to the roof; the apartment’s dress code was minimal on its best day. Running hands through her hair, Tori checked the mirror and found a normal, everyday woman in her mid-twenties staring back.

She paused, looking the image over with a critical eye. What she was planning would mean using the spotlight that had been thrust upon her, but in doing so, she’d likely never escape it again. Image was going to be a thing she’d have to care about, inasmuch as it furthered her goals. Controlling the perception was key, especially at the start. How she looked would be the first thing people noticed, and the furthest she might get, if her choices were not calibrated properly. It wasn’t that she was looking to tart things up, more that she needed to project a specific image. This was a matter to consult on with Beverly, once things were a bit further along. For today, Tori was happily resigned to some much-needed mundanity.

With the mirror-check done, she stepped out of her room and into the kitchen. To her shock, she entered to find Beverly halfway shifted into her green dragon form, glaring at a strange woman shivering in a bathrobe, kitchen knife clutched tightly in her shaking hands.

It was such an insane scene that she genuinely thought her mind was mistaken, improperly processing the visual information being sent. But a few quick blinks changed nothing, except to bring a few more details to Tori’s attention. For one, the woman was absolutely breathtaking, the sort of inhuman beauty it took celebrities and special effects to achieve. Her looks

clashed with the worn, lime-green bathrobe that didn't fit her statuesque body. In fact, it didn't look right on her at all, because Tori *knew* that robe.

That was when it clicked, and while Tori was making some serious deductive leaps, she also trusted her gut as she stepped forward, quickly putting herself between Beverly and their apparent intruder.

"Calm it down," Tori ordered, very nearly reaching forward to pop Beverly on the nose. "You're scaring the piss out of Chloe."

That earned a pause in the glowering as Beverly's already green eyes, tinged with a hint of magic, scanned the shivering woman once more. This time, she was probably taking in the fact that their "intruder" had come unarmed, as that was *their* kitchen knife, and was dressed in a bathrobe that also happened to belong to a roommate who wasn't present. One with strange, hard-to-define powers, capable of truly unpredictable effects.

"That's Chloe?" Beverly sounded normal, so evidently, her tongue hadn't gone dragon-shaped yet.

"Of course, it's me!" Chloe sounded much the same, a slight husk to her voice lost in the near terror. She looked down at herself, eyes widening. "Shit! Sorry. I came in here to show you this, but then you whirled on me, and I sort of panicked."

The three of them stood like that for a moment, until Beverly's body started to shift, slowly morphing back to a fully human form. "Apologies. I'm a little on edge, given everything. How did you change your entire body, though?"

A sheepish look came over the stunning face they were looking into. "I was in the shower, thinking about phrases, and one I hadn't tried popped into my head. Turns out, once you say that beauty is only skin deep..."

As Chloe explained, Tori turned her attention to putting on a pot of coffee. Day off or not, the way things were shaping up, she was definitely going to need it.

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## Chapter 40

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“At first, nothing happened. Then I noticed some of my skin peeling a little in the water. Not much, not even sunburn level—just like the dead, dry skin coming off. Soon, more was coming, and after a few seconds, the whole top layer washed away to reveal... this.”

Chloe spread her arms, pulling the bathrobe to dangerous heights. Her new form filled it out far more fully than the original, with ample hips and chest, capable shoulders, and toned limbs. Flowing chestnut hair, pouty lips—it was like she’d been built using photo manipulation software. “Neat trick, right?”

Neat was one way to put it. Terrifying was another. Chloe’s power was like Captain Bullshit’s, in that it played entirely by its own rules and logic. Sudden shower-shapechanging like that should be harder, should take some kind of toll, but all Chloe had needed was to find the right words. This was one just more innocuous trick, yet Tori couldn’t help wondering how long it would be until Chloe found the words to something dangerous, the sort of ability that would put her on the wrong people’s radar.

“Here’s my thing, though, isn’t beauty subjective? Like, yes, you are a stone-cold knockout right now, but what part of your ability determines what we value in the looks department?” Beverly had shifted from attack to analysis as soon as the situation became clear. She leaned across the kitchen counter, nearly knocking over her own mug of coffee, scanning Chloe more closely.

“I hadn’t considered that,” Chloe admitted. “Maybe based on what I consider to be beautiful? Or an average of everyone in the area’s general



preferences? It's a good point. You never really know what one person will like over another."

Tori said the words on reflex, not fully considering the implications. "Beauty is in the eye of the beholder."

Silence filled the room. Eyes turned to Tori first, then to Chloe, as the same thought echoed simultaneously through all three heads. Beverly broke the word embargo, tapping her finger against the counter. "You don't think..."

"No reason I can see why it wouldn't," Tori replied. "Then again, I'm not the expert."

"But you're right. It makes sense in theory," Chloe agreed. "Same principle, and I can see how it would work. What the hell—let's make a morning of it. **A penny saved is a penny earned.**"

It seemed like nothing happened. Then Tori blinked, and Chloe was back to her old self again. The core limit of Chloe's power appeared to be that she could only sustain a single saying at a time. Changing it up canceled out the lingering effects of her last one—in this case, at a rapid pace.

"Figured I should set myself back to normal for a first test. Okay, here we go. **Beauty is in the eye of the beholder.**"

Taking a cue from the last minute, Tori voluntarily closed her eyes, giving the power time to work. Ideally, this would make for a smoother transition, and Chloe hadn't accidentally summoned a fantasy monster by mistake. Slowly, Tori peeked, scoping out the new-new-Chloe.

At first, she thought it hadn't worked, but that was only because she'd been expecting another complete overhaul. Instead, this Chloe looked more like a relative of the original. Same basic structure, only everything had been elevated: flawless skin, defined muscle, her face reshaped slightly, and her white-blonde hair now well past her shoulder.

"Oh, neat. You look good as a brunette." Beverly was also staring, though based on her comment, they weren't getting the exact same picture.

"Interesting. She's still blonde to me," Tori said.

Chloe hopped up from the counter, a gleam of excitement in her eye. "Hang on, let me get a pen and paper. You can both write down what you see, and then we'll compare. Let's test what this new saying can do!"

While it wasn't technically a very normal start to a day, Tori was spending her morning goofing around with her friends. That part mattered

more than staying within the confines of the mundane. Besides, the scientist in her was always piqued by experimentation.



In terms of this project, there was a nuclear option—one that Rick was hesitant to pull, fearing both the blast and the fallout. He contemplated that as he typed on the computer, keenly aware these efforts were largely fruitless. So far, his research had gone nowhere. Whoever had hidden his father's true identity was skilled *far* beyond anything he could manage with some scrounged-up hacking programs. Each bit he'd pulled for Tori was the same. Everything lined up. Every document, every piece of history, all of it told a cohesive story of a young woman who'd lost her family young, fallen into drugs, and finally gotten her life together with the help of a distant uncle. Except there *was* no link between her family and Ivan, because Ivan had either been lying to them their entire life, or he truly had no family to speak of. Or both.

That didn't mean he was entirely out of paths forward, however. Rick was old enough to read between the lines; he knew his parents didn't have the most amiable relationship post-divorce. They were good about keeping that behind the scenes, always presenting a united front to their kids, but there were too many seams for some not to show. Whatever this secret was might impact his mother's willingness to share it with him. Alternatively, there was a chance this could be something bad. Something that would paint his father in a new light, the sort of thing she might agree not to tell, yet would confirm if he figured it out on his own.

Crazy as that idea seemed, his dad was so boring, and the mystery was stirring up all sorts of confusion. Finding out Ivan had kept this secret their whole lives... it was hard not to wonder what else he was hiding. Rick was a curious, determined boy; however, he *was* still a child. The possibility of changing the way he viewed his father scared him in ways he wasn't entirely capable of processing. Like all teens, he felt a healthy sense of rebellion and resentment toward those who held control, but Ivan was still his dad. If pressed, and placed into a state more capable of emotional honesty, Rick might have even admitted that he was a good father, at that, supportive and caring in his own way. Despite the distant demeanor, Rick

had never for a moment wondered if he had his father's love. Ivan was always there when it counted, and often when it didn't. Firm, but never harsh or cruel. He couldn't even remember Ivan ever yelling at either him or Beth. Misbehavior was met with disappointment and stern discussions.

The mental image of his dad teaching Beth to swim at the community pool didn't quite mesh with the idea of a whole secret life... except for a moment, when Rick's mind flickered. It wasn't the pool anymore. It was a shoreline. Sand, waves, the screech of gulls in the distance. The water was wrong, though. Seawater didn't have viscous streaks of purple woven through it.

Just like that, the image was gone, leaving only a headache in its place. Rick realized his hands had gone still, and sweat dripped from the bottom of his chin onto the keyboard. Hopping up, he ran into the bathroom and noticed the shine on his entire face. He grabbed a towel and wiped away the excessive moisture, then splashed himself with cold water to cool off.

What the hell? A chunk of some image caused that kind of reaction? An image of someplace he wasn't even sure he'd ever been, at that. Rick felt his whole mind rebel at that thought, bringing him up short. No, it was a memory. Every part of his brain insisted that it was authentic, ignoring the utter lack of supporting evidence he could produce.

Whatever he was seeing, it rattled him. Despite the cooldown, Rick's heart was still racing as he sat once more at the computer. All he knew for sure was that it was tied to memories of his father, and the ocean. A new idea poked his brain, slithering up from the terror of his sudden near-panic attack.

Closing out the web browser, Rick instead began rooting around the home's shared folder. Three years prior, Rick's stepdad had digitized all the family's old albums as a birthday gift for Janet. They now lived on a folder tucked away on the massive memory bank connected to the network, and after a couple of clicks, Rick had pulled them up.

A few from his birth—only mom in those. Ivan had allegedly been stuck across town due to a meta-attack. Skimming ahead, Rick noted that the timeline seemed to jump from birth to his first birthday, where Ivan was presenting a lopsided, homemade cake. Under his breath, Rick resisted a snort. His father was usually a much more fastidious cook than that. Skimming ahead again, he was looking at himself as a child, next to a baby Beth just brought home from the hospital. Both parents were there this time,

Janet presenting Beth to Rick while Ivan looked like a pack mule who only hauled baby supplies.

The more Rick skimmed, the sillier his concerns seemed. This was ridiculous. He knew who Ivan was. Some strange parts of the man's past didn't change the dad he'd always been. Rick was very near giving up, ready to switch over to college prep, when a new picture popped up on screen. Ivan and Janet waving at the camera. Rick looked about four or five, which would put Beth near one. They were all smiling, the sun shining down overhead—onto hot sand. It was a beach.

No... it was *the* beach. The one Rick had just seen. His whole stomach seized up, and his hands began to shake. He couldn't even look at it without feeling his brain spasm. Something was off. Wrong. Something had happened there, a memory his brain very clearly didn't want him dragging to the surface. Rick's determination set at that realization. When it had been a mere curiosity, that was one thing. But the deeper he dug, the more serious things were growing. It was starting to feel like this was bigger than he'd realized.

Perhaps it was time to go nuclear after all.



It wasn't often they met in the day. Work, life, and general habits meant they tended to find their time free in the evenings, at least until duty beckoned once more. Sometimes, however, circumstance demanded speed over convenience. There were issues that couldn't wait until the time was right; they had to be dealt with as quickly as possible.

“—and that's all we've managed so far. Vernon is working to analyze the remains of what we brought back, the whole AHC is in a tizzy over getting caught with our pants down, and consequently, I'm probably going to have to do a mass evaluation this weekend. Real crapshow all over the place.”

“About the same,” Ivan agreed, helping himself to a donut from the sizable box he'd brought. The sugary ones were for Penelope when she was back from day camp. He stuck to a simple kruller. “Not the evaluation part, but Wade is bothered by the fact that someone managed to beat him at tech, even if only for a day. Nobody is taking it lightly.”

Helen dipped into the box as well, grabbing a donut so filled with cream and sugars she could have never allowed her daughter to eat it in good conscience. Since she, on the other hand, was functionally immortal, the carbs weren't quite such a concern. She did pause to grab a paper towel off her counter before diving in, though, managing to spare her kitchen island from the first errant blob of cream.

"The real question is: what's their next move? Tori was a test run; pretty sure we're all on that same page. Nothing we saw spoke to a sincere attempt by a legitimate threat. When whoever was really running things starts playing for keeps, I don't think the stakes are going to be one civilian snatched off the street."

This was, by Ivan's estimation, the hardest point in dealing with a new enemy: figuring out what they wanted. Power, skill, competence, all of that could be handled in the moment, but knowing an opponent's goal was the greatest power one could have. It was a compass, guiding him toward them at every turn, showing the things they cared about. Until he knew that, he was playing at a disadvantage. Worse, there was a chance that someone this good knew his real identity, and that put Ivan's own family at risk. Odds that they were coming to pick a fight with a murdering legend were slim, but it had happened before. Plus, as much as they wanted to assume Tori was a coincidence, there was always the chance it wasn't.

"I've got nothing, and I hate it," Ivan admitted. "No clues, no hunches, not even a direction to punch in. Which is a shame, because my fists are positively itching."

From across the kitchen island, Helen's hand landed daintily on his forearm. "Keep a leash on it, tough guy. Tearing up every hideout and den in the underworld isn't actually going to help, especially with someone this careful."

"Be assured, I have no intent to dole this anger out where it isn't deserved." Ivan paused to tear off a sizable chunk of kruller that he swallowed in a single gulp. "But they stole my apprentice off the street, lashed her to a chair, and threatened her life. Whoever set that in motion will answer to me."

"Only if you get there first." It was said teasingly, yet both clocked the seriousness in one another's eyes. She would strive to bring the threat in, while Ivan would fight to put it down. "Maybe you could come on board

and team-up for this one. I bet we can find you a costume with a big helmet to hide your face, sell you as some new heavy hitter.”

Helen’s eyes lit up as the idea took hold. She even rubbed her hands together, a habit she’d long ago had to break while in Lodestar form. “Oh my god, this weekend is the mass evaluation—we could totally smuggle you in with the other rookies! Now *that* would be a hell of a way to drive home the ‘don’t take any threat lightly’ point, some newbie managing to go a few rounds with Lodestar.”

“Aside from the myriad of reasons that’s already a bad idea, I’d never be able to actually fight you without displaying a sizable amount of my power, enough to endanger bystanders.”

“Ivan, I’m not actually going to have you throw down in front of a bunch of new superheroes. It’s just a fun thing to imagine,” Helen assured him. “I mean, don’t get me wrong: I would love to have a chance to let them fight Fornax in a controlled environment, really drill in the difference in power levels without me having to do it.”

Once, Ivan might have missed the flicker of sadness in Helen’s eyes at the prospect. To most of them, she was more legend than person, known for her world-saving exploits. However, what came soon was going to be worse. Right now, the stories were just stories, myths that many no doubt took to be exaggerations. After a mass evaluation, they were going to understand the gulf between where they were and where the top was far, far better. It was a good lesson, one villains needed as much as capes, yet one that weighed heavily on Helen. Because after they understood, they’d grow more distant. Rarely out of fear or malice; it was just the way people behaved among those that were so much stronger than they.

It was lonely at the top. For a brief time, they’d gotten to share that position, but those days were long past. Now, all Ivan could do was remind her that no matter how many people called for Lodestar, some still preferred to spend their time with Helen.

“While Fornax might not be a good fit for an AHC event, you and I also have some business to discuss regarding this week’s Starscouts meeting. The End of Summer Shindig is coming up in a couple of weeks, so we’ll want to make sure to go over that at the top, as well as have handouts for the parents with relevant information. I think they changed the location and fee structure this year, so we’ll want to make sure to highlight those points.”

Helen groaned with such theatricality Ivan half suspected she was stealing the technique from Penelope. “Geez, it’s all work, work, work, with you. Don’t you ever—”

A bright, blinking light appeared on Helen’s wrist, atop what appeared to be a perfectly normal watch. In a literal flash, Helen was gone, replaced by the glowing form of Lodestar. She disappeared in a blur, already changed before zipping through a secret tunnel that led out of the house. By the time Ivan took another bite of kruller, Lodestar was already in the sky, racing to respond to whatever threat the AHC deemed appropriate.

In the meantime, Ivan got to work making a rough outline of the Starscout End of Summer Shindig information for the other parents. Lodestar could handle whatever she was facing alone, but Helen would be glad to have the job started when she got back.

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## Chapter 41

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By the time they made it up to the rooftop pool in the early afternoon, Captain Bullshit's strange snow had finally ceased, and the flowers growing on every external surface had wilted to nothingness. All that remained of his exploit were the memories, and the *heat*. Despite the fact they were cusp on fall, the thermometer read like they were summering in the desert. A weather shift like that would have ample effects, many of them negative, but one upswing was that it made for perfect poolside weather.

As Chloe mounted her pink-and-black umbrella onto a stand, creating a shady spot to protect her pale skin, Tori watched her work. She looked normal now, but the morning's experimentation had confirmed that her new phrase allowed her to look different to each person viewing her. Tori and Beverly's descriptions were hardly worlds apart, yet if someone had been taking witness statements, they'd never think both women had been talking about the same person. It was a potent talent, one Tori could envision countless espionage uses for.

Instead, Chloe would probably only ever use it as a party trick, or maybe as a way to boost tips if the coffee shop was running slow one day. And the more Tori thought about it, the happier she was that this unpredictable power was in the hands of someone like Chloe. Flying and fire, even magic, that was all one thing. The powers that fucked with the very foundation of how the world worked scared Tori; she much preferred them in the hands of people who saw them as novelties rather than weapons.



Together, the three women got settled on the far side of the pool, occupying some of the faded and sagging loungers provided by the apartment complex. Once Chloe was under her shade, she began the process of liberally applying ample sunscreen, easily triple the amount that Beverly was using. Tori got to skip that step, since she didn't burn—one of the handier side effects of fire-based abilities.

For the first ten minutes, it was peaceful. A quick dip, a little muddling about, the afternoon breeze stirring up their overheated city. Tori lay in the sun, her mind drifting, contemplating new ideas for her next project. She had to do this right. She only had one chance to launch, and she'd be capitalizing on the kidnapping, so time was a factor. Whatever she kicked off with would have to be just right; there probably wasn't going to be a second chance. Not like this.

*Bam.* The rooftop door slamming open jarred Tori out of her contemplation and drew a squeak from Chloe. Seconds later, a familiar voice rumbled out from the shadows. "Sorry! I thought it was heavier."

Austin walked into the sunshine, clad in board shorts and a large t-shirt, a suitably shameful expression on his face. No sooner had he actually scanned the roof than his whole body changed. Seizing up, the relaxed ease left him, and he barely managed to take a few steps forward to let his roommates out. "Hello, neighbors. I didn't expect to see you here."

Yeesh, Tori could even hear the tension creeping into his voice.

"Who the shit are you talking to? Wait, why am I back here? I can see the light." In a pop, Ike appeared in front of Austin, while Ellie worked her away around through the doorway. "Ohhh, it's the cute neighbor girls. I gotcha."

"By this point, shouldn't you know our names?" It wasn't an especially barbed comment, but that might have just been thanks to Chloe's constant casual demeanor.

A quick slug smashed into Ike's shoulder, courtesy of Ellie's fist. "Yes, he should, and I'm sure he does." She, unlike most of the attendees, had walked up in her swimsuit without any sort of cover up. It wasn't absolutely risqué, but it was definitely more skin-forward than anything Tori would have chosen. Then again, as she was in a simple red one-piece designed for lap-swimmers, that wasn't saying much. It was probably about on par with Beverly's bikini, which still meant it was well outside Tori's comfort zone.

On Ellie, however, it was stunning. Tori watched the woman, remembering Ike's picture of the old her. Whoever had done the work was good. There were no signs that her beauty was anything but natural. Part of Tori wondered if that made the whole thing better, or worse.

As Kyle followed Ellie out, shoving Austin another few inches forward, Ike teleported over to their area, hunkering down next to Chloe. "You know, some people would be complimented by being called cute."

Lowering her oversized vintage sunglasses slightly, Chloe met Ike's eye, then reached out and gently ruffled his hair. "Sorry, bud. I had my sad-boy-hiding-his-pain-through-asshole-behavior phase already, and I'm not looking for a do-over. Why don't you aim your words in the same direction as your heart?" Pointedly, Chloe glanced over to Ellie, whom Ike had thought he was carefully ignoring.

It was the first time Tori had seen Ike absolutely flattened, and Chloe had done it with a comforting tone. He stared at her, ignoring the rest of his team settling in on another set of chairs, mouth opening twice before he finally responded. "You're dangerous, aren't you?"

"Like you wouldn't believe. So play nice." With that, Chloe popped her sunglasses back up and laid into her chair, signaling the conversation was done.

For a few minutes, peace returned. The New Science Sentries unloaded their own gear—towels and coolers and the like—while the two secret villains and a not-so-secret barista lounged in the warm air. As their neighbors finished getting ready, attention turned to the pool. Kyle went in first, popping his shirt off, and Tori was unsurprised to see the usual build of a super-speed meta. The man ran lean, toned to the point of being shredded thanks to nonstop cardio and training. Austin was close behind him, pausing only to remove the oversized t-shirt hiding his torso.

"Oh *my*." The words had slipped from Beverly's mouth without warning, earning her a cocked eyebrow from Tori.

"Was that a George Takei impression? I didn't know you watched any Multerion Collection flicks, let alone the sci-fi stuff."

"Never got into movies from other universes, so I have no idea who you're talking about," Beverly admitted. "I, um, must have been thinking and something nonsensical slipped out."

"Come on now. That's not even my particular flavor of ice cream, and I can admit it's a well-made sundae," Chloe chimed in.

She wasn't wrong. Austin was nothing if not properly put together. He'd always been large—that went with the territory of physical strength more often than not—but this was the first time they could see just how well conditioned he was. What he wielded wasn't simply mass, built by repeatedly lifting heavy objects. It was the honed muscle of someone who put their strength to work, constantly and continuously.

Unfortunately, Ellie had chosen that moment to get near enough to overhear. “Hang on, if *that* isn't your flavor, what is?” The hungry look she tossed over her shoulder left no question about Ellie's own appreciation for her leader's physique.

“What's the ice cream equivalent of pansexual? Rainbow sherbet? I'm going to say rainbow sherbet,” Chloe decided. “I more meant I'm not into the huge look. My preference leans toward people closer to my size.”

Though she didn't say it, on that point, Tori and Chloe were agreed.

Ellie, however, merely shook her head. “No accounting for taste, I suppose. At least this gal is with me.” Ellie held up a hand for Beverly to high-five, which she did, after noticing it a few seconds too late to not get chuckled at. Clearly, Beverly had no such qualms about the muscle-bound physique.

It wasn't long past then that the heat drove more of them into the water, forcing dips to cool down. Although she was unaffected, Tori did the same, careful not to draw too much attention to herself, even for something as simple as high heat tolerance. This game they were playing was dangerous. The closer they got to the New Science Sentries, the worse the blowback could be if they learned the truth. But the rooftop pool was a shared space, and ultimately, Tori was finding she didn't mind the quartet entirely. Outside of the costumes, they made decent company. When not hallway drinking, that was.

By the time Kyle finally approached Tori on his own, waiting until the rest of the group was distracted messing with a portable charcoal grill, she was already waiting for him. His nervous, shamed glances had been coming her way all day, and while they'd spoken, it had only been in brief, passing snippets of casual conversation. She'd seen him gathering his courage, and even gone off on her own to present an opportunity. Better to get this done with, especially while everyone was in a good mood.

“Hey,” he greeted her, as if they hadn't just spent several hours together. “I, uh, wanted to talk to you about last night.”

“Good news: you didn’t take a swing, use a slur, or try to grab my ass, so we’re fine.”

That stunned him for a moment; Kyle moved in silence as he took a seat on the unoccupied lounge next to Tori, resting in the shade of Chloe’s curiously colored umbrella. “Nice to know, I guess, but I didn’t think I’d have done any of that in the first place.”

“Makes you a nicer drunk than most people I’ve known,” Tori shot back. “Look, I know you feel bad, but really, why? You got weekday drunk? Big whoop, we both know you cleared a hangover within the first ten minutes of waking up, so there’s no long-term consequences. All you did with me was apologize, so nothing bad there. Unless you took a piss in this pool last night and are only just now revealing it, I truly don’t get where all this guilt is coming from.”

“But I’m a superhero,” Kyle protested.

“So the fuck what? It’s a *job*. It doesn’t define who you are, or what you can be. Hell, if you want to get technical, you’re only a superhero when you’re in costume, and last night, I saw Kyle getting hammered. No Tachyonic in sight. The reason capes wear masks is so they can take them off and be normal people when the day is done.”

In truth, this was some of her own villain education being repurposed and repackaged, but the point was a sound one. Ivan had helped her build multiple identities for a reason, beyond just secrecy. Different feelings, different ambitions, they might not all fit the same side of her. Some things were for Tori, others for Hephaestus. The villain in her, for example, realized how much work time she was wasting sitting in the sun, comforting a cape, but she made no attempt to leave. The human part of Tori deserved her downtime.

“When I go running in costume, people cheer. They scream my name, try to slap my hand if I’m passing close. They’re already looking up to me. I saw kids wearing Tachyonic shirts yesterday, but it feels like I’ve just been fucking up nonstop since we got here. Last night was one more log on the guilt fire, I guess.”

“How many people has Tachyonic saved?” Tori asked. “Since arriving in Ridge City, I mean.”

Kyle took a moment, doing some mental calculations and perhaps a few ticks on his hands. “Rough estimates, about seventy-five, though I’m

rounding a little on how many people were on the bus I stopped a few days ago.”

“Sounds to me like you’re doing fine. It’s not your job to inspire, or be a perfect symbol, or some flawless beacon of justice. Showing up when people truly need you is a superhero’s only real job. Be there, help people, turn certain deaths into near-misses. Give people their futures back.”

“And don’t forget the receipt in the bag.” The smirk on Kyle’s mouth was tentative, yet distinct.

Despite herself, Tori laughed. “Look at that, you’re already learning. A proper rescue protects them from all threats, meta as well as meta. Cat’s out of that bag now, though.”

As peace settled between them, Tori thought their conversation had reached its end. Based on the bursts of flame shooting up from the grill, dinner would go from raw to burned in rapid succession, so they’d likely be eating soon. She was expecting Kyle to get up and mosey over. Instead, he settled deeper into the lounge.

“You know, for someone who acts like she doesn’t give a crap about superheroes, you’ve sure given a lot of thought to their purpose.”

“Not especially. But I’ve seen what happens when there is no last-minute miracle... no cape swinging in with a power to fix everything, no sudden shift in a seemingly inevitable fate.” Warm air be damned, Tori could still feel the chill from that damned hospital room. “You only have to witness that once to know the other version is better.”

A glance at Kyle showed her a man conflicted. He clearly wanted to know more, but was also perceptive enough to notice that this wasn’t some hypothetical situation she was describing. After a brief struggle, he formed his next words carefully. “Tori, I’m still getting to know you, and I feel like half our chats end with me saying the wrong thing, so I’m just going to be plain. If that was cryptic because you don’t want to talk specifics, we can end it there. If it was to get me to dig deeper, I’m happy to listen.”

“Asking was the right call. It’s definitely the former,” Tori confirmed. “But by this point, I know you have it in a file somewhere, so let’s just get this done. My parents died due to an accident at a lab that made them violently, briefly ill. Their only hope was someone with meta-tech or powers, none of which came through. And that is the maximum I want to talk about it.”

Another pause in the conversation, this one shorter than the last.

“My parents gave me away,” he told her. “My mother was part of a prenatal setlium exposure test to see if powers could be reliably created by introducing it early. The answer was no, it didn’t work reliably, but some of us did beat the odds. When she produced a meta-human baby, Professor Quantum made an offer. That was it. I don’t even know their names. He says he destroyed all records for security, to make sure no one could use our biological parents as leverage. I don’t want to talk about it, either, mind you. This isn’t something I go around tossing out as a fun fact in interviews. But it only felt right to square us up.”

That was not the origin story Tori had expected; however, she was hardly blown away. After hearing Ike’s story, she was getting a sense of Professor Quantum, and it didn’t paint the kindest of pictures. The positive work he did for the world was undeniable. It was his methods that gave Tori pause.

If these were the projects people talked about, what kind of dealings went on behind the scenes?

Luckily, Professor Quantum was an Ivan-level issue, the sort of thing she didn’t have to bother herself with. No, today, Tori’s primary concern was unwinding and having fun with her friends. Along with the New Science Sentries, apparently, which didn’t annoy her as much as it would have just days prior.

“Thanks,” Tori said, climbing up from her chair. “That’s probably enough time in the sad-sack corner. Burgers and beers?”

In a blur, he was at her side, eyes already trained on the smoking grill. “You think any of those will be edible?”

“What the hell, just this once, I’ll try being an optimist.”

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## Chapter 42

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After the strange snow that blanketed Ridge City on Thursday, the city got too hot for crime. That was Donald's working theory, anyway. It explained why they'd had such a light Friday, and apparently, the AHC expected so few issues on Saturday that the entire class of rookies was being gathered together for a training exercise.

Making his way down the halls, he tried not to fiddle with his Cyber Geek costume. Despite having worn it for months now, being crammed in around so many others in similar outfits had him nervous. Something was up, and he had a hunch it was more than just training. From the tense way Ren was moving at his side, the feeling was mutual. Irene had a steely gaze as well, and even Lucy seemed to be aware things weren't as they seemed.

Every rookie member of the AHC—those from the last confluence, as well as some who'd picked up powers haphazardly in between—gathered together in a vast hall clearly meant for larger audiences. Donald even noticed the New Science Sentries not too far off; apparently, this really was an all-hands-on-deck kind of meeting. Waiting there, at the center of the hall, glowing as expected, stood Lodestar. She hovered a few feet above a raised stage, making herself impossible to miss.

"File on in, everyone. We've got a lot to get through and never enough time." Motioning, Lodestar directed them to move to the front so as to open the entrances for those still streaming in. By the time all of them were there (somewhere around ninety aspiring superheroes), Lodestar had drifted back down to the stage's level.

“Thank you all for coming today,” she said, as though the meeting hadn’t been listed as mandatory on all of their schedules. “I’m sure you’re wondering what this is about, and I’m not much of one for needless suspense. To put it bluntly, some of you have grown beyond the roles you are filling. With the betrayal of Apollo, our training system was severely weakened, yet you have continued to flourish even as our efforts have gone toward larger threats. We have decided to recognize that effort by offering those who wish to take on harder, more dangerous threats the opportunity to do so.”

At his side, Donald could hear Ren’s tail flex at the words. While he’d never publicly complained, Donald knew his friend was craving a greater challenge. After starting off with fighting villains and a gang riot, dealing with muggers just didn’t offer the same ways to test one’s self.

“However, that does not mean we can simply hand you harder tasks. Because the truth is, while some of you are ready to move on, some of you need more time to hone your fundamentals. I confess, right now, I don’t even know with certainty which of you is which. I’ve been too absent from your training to know what you can do, *really* do, when everything is on the line. That is my failing, and it is one I intend to remedy today.”

Stepping forward, Lodestar walked closer to the stage’s edge, one foot actually going over and planting itself in the air like it was solid ground. “There is no shame in continuing to train your fundamentals, either. Some of the most famous heroes you know spent years doing these tasks, and a lone person being attacked in the night would be just as happy to see you as the person strapped to an out-of-control bus full of dynamite. The threat doesn’t matter. The person you’re helping does. That said, if there are some of you who feel as though your talents could be better utilized by taking on greater threats, then I can certainly respect the sentiment. Anyone who wants to find out if they’re ready, come see me in five minutes. As a team, as a person, talk it over and make your choice. Just know that whatever formation you choose is the one you’ll be given assignments as moving forward.”

Her feet didn’t even move this time. She just slid back, floating to the rear of the stage as conversation burst forth from the barely contained crowd.

Donald took his time turning to face Ren, keenly aware of the enthusiasm that would be waiting for him. To his surprise, Ren was scratching



under his cheek whiskers, a sign that he was lost in thought.

“I think we should do it.” In a twist, Irene was the one who spoke up first. “It’s been weeks since the street-level crime was an actual threat. There has to be a better way to use us.”

“For the record, I agree,” Ren said. “But it has to be mentioned that taking on more dangerous jobs also means playing against potentially serious threats. We all saw Fornax beat the living shit out of Apollo, who was way stronger than any of us. If we do this, we have to be okay with going up against someone substantially outside our weight class.”

“That could happen just as easily doing street work. There are always new metas to discover. I’m on Team Go-For-It. Even if we don’t pass, we’ll see areas where we can improve.” Lucy had been Donald’s final expected holdout. With her voicing support, the will of the team was clear.

He certainly wouldn’t be the one to stand in the way. “Okay then, I guess we’re going for it. Whatever ‘it’ is, in this case.”

They didn’t have to wait long. Making their way to the front of the hall, they joined the place where many of their peers were already waiting for Lodestar. A quick scan of the room showed that while a large percentage of the rookies were taking the challenge, there was also a sizable group hanging back. Some were new; others had joined after the same confluence as Donald and the majority of his team. There didn’t seem to be much rhyme or reason to the sorting; people were making the choice based on where they were in their own journey. It didn’t escape his notice that the New Science Sentries were, of course, among the first ones to accept the challenge.

“Everyone who wants to skip this, thank you for coming. Enjoy a Saturday off to spend however you like. The rest of you, follow me.”

Chatter rose up on the wind of whispers as they trekked out of the room, down a hall, and into what looked like an airline hangar. Set before them was a massive metal rectangle, easily the size of a small airplane cabin, and with a single door open at the front.

“File on in and buckle up. Seriously, you do *not* want to ignore me on that. Anyone who falls outside of standard, human-sized parameters, there are some more varied restraint options toward the rear.” Lodestar waved them forward, and they complied.

The interior felt sort of like a commuter bus, if every seat was ultra-secure and triple reinforced into the framing. Donald followed Ren to the

rear, where different styles and sizes of seat options began to pop up. After a moment or two of searching, Ren found one that was large enough for his shoulders and also had a slot in the back where he could fit his tail. Donald, Irene, and Lucy all took spots nearby.

In only a few minutes, they'd all been packed into the strange box, with ample seating left over. Through the door, they could make out Lodestar's form as she gave them one final warning.

"Okay, everyone, get ready for some fun. Make sure you are locked and stowed, because once I start moving, you're going to feel it, even with all the dampening tech Professor Quantum put into this thing. All buckled in? Hope you peed already, because there are no pit-stops on this road trip."

The door slammed and sealed, leaving them with only the artificial lighting that clicked on moments later. At Donald's side, Lucy leaned over and whispered.

"She's not... is she going to carry us? Is that what she meant?"

Before Donald could answer, they felt the box shift, as if it had been pulled upward forcefully.

"I think you might be right." With a gulp and a wish that he had actually used the bathroom before they left, Donald tightened his grip on his seat. Being something of a superhero nerd meant that he had at least a passing familiarity with most of the major capes' core abilities, so he knew that Lodestar could go *fast*. Even assuming she wouldn't use her full speed, they were in for a hell of a ride.



After a Thursday spent with friends around a pool and a Friday composed largely of brainstorming coupled with catching up on life—such as touching base with Vendallia's offices—Tori was ready to use her weekend to get a jump on her new project. Armed with a few mugs of coffee in her veins and some of Chloe's breakfast bubbling in her stomach, Tori made her way down to the concrete parking units serving as her lab.

It was a mess, as always. To an outsider stepping in, it would seem impossible that Tori could find anything in this chaos. While, if pressed, she would protest that there was a system, that was also part of why Tori didn't

generally allow others into her workspace. Less explaining to do, in general.

Her first task was unpacking the Hephaestus armor. Beverly had done a good job throwing everything into a bag, but Tori took her time cataloguing every component as it was removed. She still needed to give the updated flight functions a proper test—one more task for the ever-growing list before her. Only when Tori was fully satisfied that her suit was complete and undamaged did she move her attention to an empty table.

Style would come later, with input from someone with Beverly's skills. Today was about function. The units would have to be small, portable, easy to carry and conceal. Capable of dealing with single targets as well as groups. Too much to pack into one unit—there would have to be multiple options. That worked better from a business perspective, as well: more products to roll out as time ticked on. Her methodology would be the real hurdle. She couldn't very well fill these with enhanced tech. The mere fact that no truly advanced technology ended up on the open market spoke to some sort of limiting force, be it governmental or the AHC. It had to be low enough tech to fly under the radar, while still offering a unique function.

Thinking back to her kidnapping, Tori let the sense of fear she'd been pushing down take hold. This was more than just her next venture; it was the way Tori chose to cope with what happened. She didn't get better by just talking. Her solution was to ensure that no bad experience would ever get the drop on her twice. It was part of why she'd cut off human contact after losing her parents, and why the fear in her mind was spurring her creative thinking, not hindering it.

Tori felt what it was like to be back in that moment. Uncertain of what was happening, or how to respond. What would have saved her, back then? She didn't need to entirely beat them; even just a little distance could have made escape possible. Something distracting, then, and if it slowed them down, then that was icing on the cake. An aerosolized compound in a proper vessel could do that, assuming she found the right material. The obvious fix would be pepper spray, except that didn't affect most metas with any sort of enhanced toughness.

A rogue memory floated up, and Tori began to dig through what one might have taken to be a random stack of junk. While most of her possessions had been purged by the guild during her recruitment, they'd been smart enough to save the essentials. Tori's photo of her parents that sat

at the far end of the lab, watching her work, was one such item. Another was a leather-bound book with three different mechanical traps built in. After some searching, she produced the tome, walking it over to the desk as she disengaged the various security measures. When she'd built them, they'd seemed airtight. A few months with the guild, however, and she couldn't believe how lax these safeguards were. Another task for the list, though much further down than the more pressing matters.

Tori perused the pages, looking through her own handwriting as she scoured for the formula in question. Finally, she found the spot she was looking for: a chemical compound created by some meta-tech dealer out in Oklahoma. The substance adhered to skin on contact, creating burning, itching, numbness—and that was assuming none got into the eyes. It might have been the new tear gas, except that the effects only lasted a few minutes before fading entirely. Plus, the fact that it had been cooked in a trailer and sold in old milk jugs meant that not many folks had buying opportunities.

This was one of the many tidbits Tori had scooped up in her years on the road. She was, after all, a thief on top of being an inventor, and there was no sense in recreating something when another person had kindly done the work for her. It was a good thing she'd stolen this one, too, since the original creator had died in an entirely predictable lab explosion. There would need to be testing to make this on a large scale, both in the formula itself and the effects; however, that would have to occur in guild facilities. Tori felt reasonably sure her power would protect her from an explosion, but the lab and building above wouldn't be so lucky.

In the meantime, she could start work on a small sample and the aerosolization device before today's meeting. Getting an idea of the mandatory schematics would inform the device's size and shape, which would have to be accounted for in the aesthetics phase. There was a lot more to consider than when she'd designed her Hephaestus gear, but Tori found she didn't mind. After months of training, testing, villains, and capes, it felt nice to be back on an old-fashioned build. That it presented new challenges only made it all the more enticing.

Grabbing her tools, Tori sat down at her worktable with a new, hungry gleam in her eyes. She had an invention taking shape in her mind, one that would only fade when she'd formed it in the real world. Time to fire up the metaphorical forge and start proving why she'd chosen her codename.

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## Chapter 43

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“The most important thing you need to understand is that this is not a test.” Those were the first words they heard after the metal container mercifully came to a stop and they were allowed to file out. What had greeted them was a harsh, rocky terrain that constantly shifted in elevation. It looked as if they were in the foothills of some mountainous region, one that had not been particularly touched by civilization. A few of them noticed the fact that all nearby trees in the area had been cleared out, but most had their attention stolen by the floating form of Lodestar, who spoke once they were all emerged.

“A test implies that what matters most is the pass or fail, that the results come first. That is not what we’re doing today. This is an evaluation above all else. What matters to me is how you think, act, fight, flee, and generally cope with challenges as I throw them at you. Some of you might very well fail the task and still be moved up based on the skills displayed. Conversely, it’s possible to succeed so recklessly that you prove yourself not ready for added responsibilities. This is just a structure to let me see what you can do. Still, with all of that said, success sure doesn’t hurt your case, so I expect everyone to give it their all.”

In a blur, she vanished, reappearing with a large hunk of stone grabbed from elsewhere on the mountain. Before their eyes, she ran her hands along it, smoothing off the rough surfaces, shaping it into a sphere with casual ease. Her position in the sky shifted higher and further back; she was moving so everyone could see her.

Once the rock was smoothed, a task that took only seconds, she held it aloft. “This is the target. About a hundred and fifty pounds of stone. Your task is to get it away from me. There are more complex versions of this same drill we use at every level, so I’d learn it well. Sometimes, we have actual targets that have to be treated like they were alive, all the way up to human dummies that can report injuries. Today is the simplest version, though. Get the rock. Everyone, stay put for a moment.”

With a toss, Lodestar hurled the stone straight up into the air. Once it was gone, she zipped further off, to an area with several rocky outcroppings. Floating higher, a pair of beams fired from her hands as she spun around in place. Once the searing lights faded, they could all make out a near perfect circle that had been scorched into the ground, even from so far off. The trails of smoke rising from the rocks certainly helped.

Satisfied with her work, Lodestar floated back over to where her charges were waiting.

“The rules are straightforward: take the rock out of the circle. I don’t care what powers you use—nothing is off-limits—but you have to make physical contact with the target before manipulating it. Conflict is the point of this, so tricks from the sidelines won’t tell me much. You can come on your own, or as teams, but before you deci—”

Lodestar paused to catch the rock she’d tossed up, the stone sphere having fully completed its airborne journey. “Sorry, as I was saying, before you decide, there are some factors you need to know from my end. So far as base physical attributes go, I’m going to match the best of what your teams offer. That means I’ll move as quick as the fastest members, hit as hard as the strongest—you get the idea. The caveat being that I’m obviously not going to seriously injure you. I also can’t exactly hold back my own toughness—not that it would be smart to, anyway—but I’ll try to react to attacks as if I’m your hardest member. That means, the more team members you add, the higher my different levels could be. Past that, I’m only going to use flight and energy blasts. I want you to have a sincere challenge, not an insurmountable one.”

She didn’t use her super-speed this time. Instead, Lodestar flew purposefully to her seared circle, dropping down to deposit the stone in the dead middle. Now that they were looking at the spot with analytical eyes, a few of the capes realized she’d chosen an area with lots of natural features

that facilitated stealth. They had the ability to attempt surprise, or could come in swinging.

Once the rock was in place, she zoomed back, taking a lower position this time that allowed for a more casual volume.

“Here’s how it’s going to go: I’ll give you ten minutes to decide your teams and your order. When I call for time, you tell me who’s coming. They have ten minutes to try to get the stone. At the end, we clean up, and I’ll call for the next group. We go like that until everyone has had their shot.”

She was met with understanding nods. For people who had been doing actual superhero work already, this was an easy enough concept to grasp. There was still one more component to drive home, however. Sometimes, it was a tough sell; other occasions went easier. Lodestar had no idea what to expect from this group—she’d never evaluated one that had survived an attempted rebellion. It would be a learning experience on both ends.

“One last thing,” Lodestar added, softening her voice carefully. “As I mentioned, I can’t turn down my own levels of invulnerability, so I want you all to come at me full force. Fight like your life is on the line, because that very well might end up being the case. Even those of you who hadn’t joined us yet saw the Ridge City Riots. I try to always choose compassion over violence, but if someone has decided that only one of you is walking away, I know which I’d prefer to see victorious. Give me all you’ve got. I want to know the limits of your abilities, and how you push them.”

Something like mischief danced in her eyes as she gave them a knowing smile. “Besides, this job is all about restraint, control, and constant awareness of how much force you’re using. It’s not often you get a chance to go all out. I bet a few of you will be glad for the chance to show what you’re truly capable of.” She lifted her arm and tapped the empty spot on her left wrist where a watch would normally go. “Ten minutes starts now. Figure out your teams and your order.”

With a casual grace, Lodestar floated off, back to her circle, where she drifted down and landed on the rock, taking a seat to wait. The moment she touched down, chaos burst forth among the rookies as they hurriedly scrambled to figure out plans.

Cyber Geek, Medley, Cold Shoulder, and Hat Trick all grouped up immediately on the far end of the metal container. Hopefully, Lodestar either couldn’t hear the discussions or was choosing not to listen, but it still

wasn't wise to give strategic hints to the other teams. They formed a huddle, minimizing the distance any individual voice had to travel.

"Quick rundown: if she's matching our top stats, that means she'll be as quick and strong as Medley, right?" Cyber Geek had no idea if this was really the best place to start, but the firm time limit meant jumping in was better than worrying about efficiency.

"I think my giant ice-armor form might hit harder," Cold Shoulder pointed out. "Potentially be tougher as well, at least up front. I can't match Medley's recovery."

"Farts, I forgot about that," Hat Trick muttered. "So even if we technically hit hard enough to 'hurt' her, she won't have to sell it for long."

The complexities of Lodestar's rules were readily becoming apparent. Teams, normally their greatest strength, also now came with liability. For every added member, they risked increasing how much power Lodestar could use in the fight. On the upside, since most of the physical strength was concentrated on Medley and Cold Shoulder, it did present a natural formation.

"We're all thinking the obvious, right? Medley and Cold Shoulder take melee to distract her, Hat Trick and I make a run for the rock?" Cyber Geek could see the lack of surprise on their faces; they'd all arrived at the same conclusion. "Unfortunately, obvious means Lodestar will see it coming, too. We need to have some curves to throw her."

Hat Trick lit up, her wide eyes practically shining. "I could put the target in my hat—get rid of the weight entirely, plus I can control it." Forehead creased in effort, she focused, and the top hat perched on her head lifted up a few inches before dropping back down. This was a new talent she'd found recently, and while it wouldn't be zipping around the battlefield, a floating hat might very well prove useful.

"The problem is, she knows about all the skills we've shown so far. Our best shot is something new," Cyber Geek said. Hat Trick's idea did stir something in his mind, a curiosity he'd held but never put to the test. Firing up the menu in his vision, Cyber Geek began to zip through his options. After Tori's kidnapping, he'd been putting more effort into utility items, and one in particular leapt to mind. The Self-Swap from *Battle Buds* would be perfect, except it only lasted for ten seconds.

"I have an idea, but we need to test something first." Motioning for his team to lean in, Cyber Geek explained the loose collection of half-thoughts



they would optimistically refer to as a plan.



This was an optimal opportunity. Beth and Juan were at the store, leaving Rick and his mother alone in the house. No work to steal her attention, no upcoming meetings to suddenly run off to. If he started this conversation, her excuses to stop it were limited. At this point, Rick was no longer sure what he was expecting. After several days, the thought of oceans and examining old photos no longer triggered attacks, but the knot of unease in his gut refused to yield.

Sitting down at the kitchen table across from her, Rick tried to see his mother as a person, rather than the role she filled in his life. Janet was working on a crossword, a favorite weekend activity. Given her levels of self-assurance and intelligence, would she really get mixed up with someone who had that much to hide? Maybe—if she hadn’t known the whole score up front. Perhaps that was even what had soured their marriage in the first place... which meant he might be about to blunder into a very sensitive topic.

Rick shook the notion from his head. He was preparing to accuse his parents of lying to him for his entire life—it would be a sensitive topic regardless of how it was phrased. The smart move would be to walk away. Except that Rick was not only the son of Ivan; Janet’s blood ran in his veins as well. Her same obsessive need to solve a complex formula burned through his mind, refusing to let go of the mystery now that it had properly taken hold. Bad as things might get, he had to push forward.

That realization was almost freeing, in a way. He didn’t have to worry about finding the right angle of approach; this was going to be a shitshow no matter how he went in. May as well cut to it, then.

“I want to know about Dad.”

Janet glanced up from the crossword, a brief squint of confusion as she noticed the serious expression on her son’s face. “Did you have a particular topic in mind? Might be best to speak to him directly.”

“I’d try that, if I thought he’d give me the truth.”

The confusion faded from her eyes as she quickly adjusted to the situation, her Saturday afternoon ease slipping away. “I see. What is it that

you're concerned he would lie to you about?"

This was it, the edge of the cliff. Once Rick started down this road, there wasn't a way back. Whatever he learned, he'd have to live with it. No matter if, or how, it changed things with his parents.

"Well, for example, there's the fact that he spent his whole life saying he has no family, only for Vendallia to list one of the other employees as his niece."

Rick waited for his mother to be shocked at the revelation. Instead, she merely threw him a gaze of pure consternation. "Oh, is that what this is all about?"

"You knew?"

"Of course I knew. He had to reach out in case anyone checked with me for confirmation," Janet replied. "For goodness' sake, Rick, you're making a conspiracy out of simple charity. That girl was on her own. Life had given her a real kicking, and Ivan saw potential. They fudged the relationship to get her an internship so she could find her footing. *You* aren't the one your father lied to."

It certainly wasn't a perfect story, opening more questions than it answered, but it did sound far more like the Ivan Rick had always known. Even the other evidence, such as Ivan getting lost in his old neighborhood, suddenly felt flimsy under Janet's reassuring gaze. His will might have broken, allowing himself to believe the lie, if not for those damn flashes from the beach.

"Okay. That explains one thing, Mom. One of a thousand inconsistencies. He's never been to the places he's supposedly lived. There are no pictures of him before you were married. I'm not even sure his age lines up—for a man in his forties, he sure doesn't seem to be showing it."

"He's a private man with a bad memory and a good metabolism. What are you digging for here?" Janet was starting to look more concerned than anything. Rick knew he was feeding that, he could already feel the sheen of sweat on the back of his neck.

"Answers. I want to know why my own dad has been hiding something. What's so bad that he couldn't even tell us? *Why* do I keep having these horrible flashes from some damn beach?"

It was the last one that landed. Until then, Janet's façade had remained firmly in place, but at the word "beach," the mask slipped away. He could

see it then, laid bare. The horror in her eyes, the terror at the idea he remembered. Something had happened.

To her credit, Janet didn't bother trying to reaffix her false expression. Instead, she walked around the table, pulling her son close in a display of affection that left him immediately uncomfortable.

"You were never supposed to see that. We tried to spare you, but the block works based on desire. When you wanted to forget, you could. If you keep trying to remember, you will."

"I don't need a hug." Rick tried to squirm away, only to be gripped tighter. "I need to know what the hell happened."

She clung for a few minutes longer, then returned to her side of the table. "I'm not so sure about that. Yes, Rick, something bad once happened at a beach. Yes, there is more to our family than meets the eye. And yes, your father has secrets he's not shared with his children. But most of what you know is true. Ivan and I are your parents, we love you more than the world itself, and we would do anything to keep you safe. Even what you know about Ivan is true. No blood relations, works a middle-management job, all very real. None of it was false. There were just *more* truths than what you were given. Sometimes, knowing more makes you miserable. You think you want those memories back, but you'll wish they were gone as soon as you succeed. You think you want to know the whole truth about this family, yet if I were to tell you, would that really make things better?"

For a moment, he'd been able to delude himself, thinking his mother had been duped as well. Hearing her speak, it was clear as could be what the actual truth was. "Whatever this is, you're in on it, too. You've been helping him lie."

"Watch it, young man. I'm still your mother." Her voice was momentarily firm, though it was short-lived despite her mounting frustration. "We both know you came to me with this because you think I'll flip on Ivan and give up the goods. What you fail to understand is that it has never been your father that I was protecting. It was you and your sister. Some truths can't be unlearned. They burrow in and chew you up from the inside."

"What makes you so sure I couldn't handle it?" Rick demanded, voice rising.

His mother's hand slapped the table, shocking him backward. "Because I *do* remember that goddamn beach, Rick! I remember every detail, every

scream, every death, and it wakes me up in a cold sweat to this day.” Only after the words had burst forth did Janet seem to realize what she’d said, calming down slightly. “Why would I ever want that for you?”

“Screams?” Rick was processing her words, trying to make sense of what she’d described. “Deaths? What the hell happened out there?”

“Maybe you’ll get the chance to find out,” she said, rising from the table once more. This time, it was not to embrace him, and Rick noticed she seemed to move visibly slower, like she was weighed down. “This is his secret to keep, and his to share if he thinks you’re ready.”

With one last look to her son, Janet reached into her purse and pulled out her cell phone. “I’m calling your father.”

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## Chapter 44

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Breaking into teams went smoothly—every cape present had been working in the field, leaning on one another and figuring out who they worked best with. In no time, they'd split apart, mostly binding themselves into units, with only a few choosing to go it alone. No one expected the solo attempts to do well, but as Lodestar had said, this was an evaluation, not a test. While winning alone might be impossible, demonstrating competence was an entirely more achievable goal.

The trouble came after the groups were split up, when the natural question arose.

"Who do you think will go first?" Lucy was staring out at the clusters of their peers, most of whom were bunched up having a similar conversation.

"First is good and bad. No standard has been set, so there's nothing to live up to. Downside is you're also the canary in the coal mine; everyone else gets to see what happens to you and adjust accordingly." Ren's voice was quiet, calm. He was mentally prepared to jump in whenever the time arrived, already focused on victory.

Irene didn't bother looking to the others. Her eyes had never left Lodestar's battlefield, committing every feature to memory while there was still time. "I'd be fine with going first, but given our team's situation, it's best if we let someone else take the spot."

It was a very polite way of pointing out that there were still some pockets within the AHC who weren't completely convinced Apollo had no corrupting influence on the capes he'd taken special interest in. They'd

been his favorites from the last confluence, and all the bitterness such a role had stirred up had found an easy outlet once he was outed as a traitor.

Personally, Donald was content to take a spot further down the list. He was better at learning and adapting, so walking in with a few samples to pull from would make the task more achievable. The trouble was, he could also feel the stares of other teams on his own. People were waiting to see if they jumped on the first spot's opening, and Donald already knew there wasn't a right answer to give. If they attempted to claim it, people would say they were trying to grab more glory. Wait for a later spot, they'd be accused of making others do the hard part while they sat back learning. Even offering to slot in wherever worked best for the groups as a whole could be read as them being so confident they didn't care when they tried. No matter what move they made, fault could be found.

That realization lessened his case of nerves slightly. If people were looking for a reason to dislike them, there would always be an angle to find. Donald should concern himself with what was best for the team and their training, which meant hanging back to let a more eager squad have first crack.

He was just about to voice that thought when the bright blue costumes of the New Science Sentries stepped into view.

"Fear not, everyone, you no longer need to worry. The top team is going to take the opening spot, sparing you all from having to face Lodestar without watching someone else show you how to win."

Presto was as untactful as usual, but to the teleporter's surprise, that actually *did* get quite a few chuckles. Unfortunately, he and the rest of his team noticed the laughs had all come when he announced them as the top team. Even without being able to see his features through the mask, Donald noticed the small body tense slightly. Presto didn't care for being part of the joke, it seemed.

The New Science Sentries, who had been striding forward confidently seconds prior, suddenly lost a step as the laughter hit. Donald could see it coming, like a slow-motion car crash. He'd been a target often enough to know how this dance played out. Strong people didn't like having their egos challenged, and the realization that their team being seen as the current best wasn't just wrong, but *laughably* wrong, was hitting most of them in the sorest of spots. Pain turned to anger, which was funneled into action, as they scanned for some outlet or place to redirect the attention.

Just as he knew they would, a pair of eyes settled on Donald and his team. When lashing out, people usually went for the easiest, most obvious target, even when it could potentially work against them.

Tachyonic stepped forward, narrowly avoiding a hand from Agent Quantum that was meant to yank him back. “Oh, I’m sorry, perhaps we should have shown a bit of deference first. My apologies, Team Apollo, did you want to display for us some of the amazing tactics he imparted? Maybe you can show us the one where superheroes lie to and betray each other.”

“I guess now we know why ‘tacky’ is part of your name.”

Had it been from Irene or Ren, Donald would have been fine. The trouble was that the line had slipped out of Lucy, who leaned more toward diplomacy and kindness. The joke, silly as it was, caught Donald completely by surprise, eliciting a sincere laugh that peeled off of him, echoing through the empty surroundings. That would have been bad enough, but this was the contagious sort of laughter. Like a giggling plague, it swept through those in attendance. With Presto, there was wiggle room to interpret what had earned the minor mirth; this time, there was no such comfort. The New Science Sentries were being laughed at, and Donald could see two faces reddening. He’d have guessed that under the full mask, Presto probably wasn’t looking too keen, either. Only Agent Quantum was keeping it stoic, though he was starting to appear visibly concerned about the situation. On that point, they were agreed. This needed to get handled, fast.

Holding up his hands, Donald stepped forward, slightly outside of his group. “Okay, that’s enough. They took a shot, we took one back. How about we all focus on the task at hand? New Science Sentries, please take the first spot. We look forward to seeing your skills. By all accounts, you’ve got quite a set of powers. I’m sure there will be a lot we can all learn.”

It was a good effort toward peace, in Donald’s opinion. Acknowledge the exchange and move past it, offer some ego-stroking as recompense, end by giving them the spot they’d wanted.

Unfortunately, the crowd was still in a chuckling mood, and some chose to interpret his words with less sincerity than they’d been spoken. More laughter sprang up, spreading once more, and with it, the faces of Tachyonic and Plasmodia both set in rage, all of it aimed at Donald.

“No, no, please, we didn’t mean to offend,” Tachyonic said. “We were trying to bite the bullet and take the worst place in the order, but since

you're so fucking sure of yourself, let's see what your team can do. Assuming you try-hards can manage anything without villains around for help."

The snort from Ren was pronounced and loud, something only his inhuman snout could manage. "You *would* think that's an insult. That the idea of effort, of trying, of striving to improve is something to be ashamed of. We didn't all get handed our team and titles from Big Daddy Quantum. The rest of us worked to be here."

Something in Ren's verbal jab hit home, and hard. Tachyonic looked like he was seconds from racing over to throw a punch, but was stopped by Agent Quantum forcibly shoving his way past.

The leader of the New Science Sentries locked eyes with Donald as he moved, a clear enough hint of what to do. Donald mirrored the movements, striding forward, away from his team, into the unoccupied space between the groups. In no time, the leaders met, surrounded, yet alone.

"One minute warning! One minute until someone's time starts!" Lodestar's voice echoed from her position on the boulder, a reminder that there was only so long to deal with this issue.

"Well, this went to hell pretty fast, huh?" To Donald's surprise, Agent Quantum had a friendly tone, despite the tense situation. "Sorry about Tachyonic. I realize that you were trying to defuse things, and I appreciate it. We need to put it to bed now, before it gets into either team's head. We're facing a hard enough task as it is. Distractions aren't going to make things any easier."

In a flicker, Agent Quantum's eyes went to Lodestar, who was perched unassumingly on her boulder as she waited. Limited or not, the idea of taking on a living legend was terrifying. If anyone wasn't fully in the fight mentally, the whole team would fall.

"No argument from me. The question is, what do we do? I'd like to find a resolution that puts this to bed, rather than potentially making it worse down the line."

"In under a minute? Sorry, I'm not that quick of a thinker," Agent Quantum replied. "Best I've got is this: you take the first slot. I know you don't want it, which is how I'm going to sell it to my team. I'll tell them we let you go first so you could fall on your face in front of everyone, and then we can go put on a better display. You could tell yours that you're going to show these egotistical jerks—that's us—by going first and scoring a win, or



whatever lights a fire under them best. We can't undo this, so let's at least make it motivational. Fallout will depend on whether you do well or not; this will get us through the evaluation, though."

For someone who'd just described himself as "not that quick of a thinker," Agent Quantum had certainly managed to come up with a comprehensive plan on the fly. It had the potential to cause more drama down the road, but Donald had to get them past one issue at a time. With the time limit bearing down, this was better than any of his own half-formed notions.

"Guess it'll have to work. Thanks for not making this harder than it had to be."

"My team is the one who started it. I'm only sorry you have to change your plans to accommodate the issue. For what it's worth, I've watched your team work, and I don't think Apollo had much influence at all. You've saved a lot of people in the time your team has been active, and I'm glad to have you counted among the superheroes."

Agent Quantum offered his hand, and Cyber Geek shook it. Their teams might have friction, but they could find mutual respect for one another. Eventually, the egos would smooth down and people would find common ground, so long as they saw that attitude flow from their leaders.

While Agent Quantum walked back to his own team, Cyber Geek motioned for his to come forward.

"Looks like we're taking the lead," he announced, loud enough for others to hear it, too. As they crowded in close, Cyber Geek summed up the situation as quickly as possible. They had to be nearly to the starting time by now.

"We're going first. Partly to keep the peace. Partly to test our limits. And partly because, if we go first and succeed, it sends a message about exactly why there was interest in us to start with. *If* we can win, that is. Are we good with that?"

The team nodded, almost in unison. It was a good thing they'd chosen a silent response, because seconds later, Lodestar's voice came bursting over the terrain.

"First team, your ten minutes starts now!"

Despite the yell, they didn't immediately scramble off. Ten minutes wasn't long, but it also wasn't a total time crunch given the terrain they had to cover. Moving carefully, going slowly to be sure of each action, offered

superior chances of success than going as fast as possible. That might get them more bites at the apple, but they'd all be long shots. Better to have fewer chances with higher potential for success. That was the idea, anyway. Whether it worked or not was yet to be seen.

“Medley and Cold Shoulder, head on in. I'll start with ranged as soon as I get to the position. Hat Trick, don't move until I've got suppressing fire going. This is Lodestar—even if she's holding back, we should assume it's going to take everything we have to keep her distracted. Once you're on the field, it's speed over everything. Keep moving. We'll have you covered.”

The eyes of his team, and all the other superheroes, were so heavy that Cyber Geek could feel them as he stood up straight. What would it be like, to have the eyes of an entire city, country—even the world—trained on him, pitting the entirety of their hopes on his power? It was a weight impossible to imagine, yet the woman they were going up against had carried it many times over. If he ever wanted to reach that level, be capable of hauling such a burden, then this was the first step in getting stronger.

To his own surprise, there was a bit of excitement in his gut, mixed in along with the nerves. Impossible task or not, he was about to spar with one of history's greatest superheroes, one he held a deep personal admiration for. Terrifying as that was on many levels, part of him was still Donald enough to appreciate that it was also fucking *awesome*. From this day on, he'd be able to say he'd tested himself against Lodestar.

The only thing better would be getting to say they'd passed.

Determination set, Cyber Geek began to move, and his team followed.

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## Chapter 45

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While her hearing was exceptional from a human perspective, Lodestar had to actually focus to tune in to more distant sounds. It was a small mercy that allowed her some peace, because the louder the world grew, the harder it was to find the voices asking for help. Information had always been her limitation. She might win every fight, but that wasn't much help if she didn't know where the opponents were. That was part of why she enjoyed this method of training. Binding down her skills, limiting the information she had: this was a way to push her own capacity for quick thinking and improvisation.

She hadn't been listening to the rookies as they made their plans. It would have given her forewarning, which worked against every aspect of the evaluation. Even without words, though, she'd caught the exchange between Apollo's old favorites and the New Science Sentries. She didn't need super-hearing to understand that friction; it was a dance every cape eventually grew familiar with. Egos and pissing matches were unavoidable when you were dealing with people this powerful. Sometimes, they laid the groundwork to amazing friendships. Other instances were the start of very long, dark rivalries. It was an issue she'd have to keep an eye on, one of the million things piled atop her plate.

Seeing Medley and Cold Shoulder burst into view, coming at her simultaneously from opposite sides, Lodestar was slightly relieved. If they were opening with a coordinated strike, they must not be too rattled from the exchange. Medley was moving faster, and Cold Shoulder hadn't

summoned her ice construct yet, so despite their timed arrival, they were likely trying something other than pure melee.

There was no more time to speculate as Medley charged right at her, opening with a swing that could have cracked a telephone pole. She'd told them not to hold back; it was good to see this group understood she wasn't kidding. The blow whipped mightily through the air, but landed on nothing, as Lodestar easily jerked her head to the side, countering with a punch of her own to Medley's stomach. It sent him back a few feet, drawing coughs from his inhuman mouth.

"You're getting bad habits. Don't fight like you're always going to be stronger and tougher than the opponent. Eventually, you won't be, and you'll realize that learning some actual skills would have been really helpful."

Medley leapt in again, launching an uncoordinated flurry. Cold Shoulder, meanwhile, was getting closer. Lodestar could see the blue power building up in her, could practically feel the chill radiating through the air. Was she going to try and encase Lodestar in ice? With these parameters, it might buy them a few seconds. That seemed like a waste of a strategy, unless one knew how powerful a few seconds in battle could truly be.

As it turned out, Cold Shoulder was going for something even stranger. Leaping up just as Medley tried to charge at Lodestar (only to be knocked aside), Cold Shoulder came slamming down with both hands. A tremendous wave of blue energy washed out along the ground, quickly solidifying into ice. The southeast quarter of the battlefield turned into a makeshift skating rink, running right up to the edge of the stone sphere without quite making contact.

Just as Lodestar was wondering what the hell that was about, she caught the first shot in her shoulder. Not bad. Decent power, good aim, and strong enough that even Cold Shoulder would have been knocked back in her armor. This team wasn't taking her lightly, thank goodness. There was nothing quite so demoralizing as having to fail a capable squad because they couldn't adjust to the challenge.

She allowed herself to fall slightly back, toward the boulder, rubbing where she'd been hit like it stung. Cyber Geek was up on a ridge; she could catch sight of his usual armor, along with the giant, oversized videogame blaster responsible for the shot. That made three out of four, and the trickiest card had yet to be played. Magic never quite made sense to

Lodestar, regardless of how often she saw it in action. It was finnick, had few rules and even more exceptions—easy to underestimate, until it wasn't. Something to watch for, between her more immediate concerns.

Leaping onto the ice, Medley's claws sank in, giving him full traction. At the same time, Cold Shoulder let loose another blast of blue energy, surrounding herself with a living construct of ice. More shots rang out from Cyber Geek, but they went wide. Probably trying to avoid hitting his teammates; Cyber Geek was hardly a sniper. They'd gotten into a decent formation. Now, they were trying to turn up the pressure.

"Two on one isn't a bad idea, but the trouble with fighting a single target is that, if they know what they're doing, they can use your own numbers against you."

That was the extent of Lodestar's warning before Medley raced in, swinging wild again. Rather than swing back, she opted to drop low, ignoring gravity for a few moments as she swept her legs between Medley's, turning him into a tumbling ball of fur and scales. With one shove to his back, Lodestar reoriented his momentum, rolling her opponent directly at his chilly teammate.

It should have ended with him slamming into Cold Shoulder's ice-construct legs, except Medley was instantly scooped up in the gigantic ice-hands that were dropped low and waiting. With the smooth expertise of someone who'd practiced this move for hours already, Cold Shoulder caught her teammate and chucked him directly back at Lodestar, claws first. Her short, terse reply as she hurled was all the explanation Lodestar needed:

"We know."

A Medley-sized projectile was enough to drive Lodestar back—when she had to play at this level, at least. It didn't stop with the launch, either. He came at her like a true wild animal, a fury of scratches and fangs. If not for Cold Shoulder's durability, Lodestar would have had to fold down under the assault.

More shots rang out, most going wide, one taking her in the back. Cold Shoulder was right. They did know the risks of fighting a single target in a confined area, and had clearly trained for it.

At last, Lodestar spotted what she'd been waiting for. Hat Trick appeared from behind a rocky outcropping, exactly opposite of place near the boulder where Lodestar was holding her ground. Three for distraction,

one to make the run. Not a bad play, especially since their runner had the wildcard of magic to work with.

With a quick motion, Lodestar fired a beam of energy into Hat Trick's legs, sending her tumbling over. That done, she floated a few inches off the ground, neutralizing Cold Shoulder's terrain trick. Medley's eyes went momentarily wild, but that was his own fault. She'd told them what powers were on the table; part of the challenge was planning around them. It did no team any favors to hold back, because the people who fought with blood on the line surely wouldn't.

A blast of ice energy nearly took her, but Lodestar dodged away in the nick of time, putting herself in the path of another energy shot. Dropping down like she'd taken a painful hit, Lodestar counted to three as she estimated how long Medley would need to recover from such an attack. The pause offered Cold Shoulder the chance to come in swinging, huge fists of ice smashing down on the ground.

This was the greatest challenge of the group, in Lodestar's original estimations. Her ice construct was durable, thick, and could be repaired if she had time to focus. Worse, none of the other members hit hard enough to do serious damage. Thankfully, Cyber Geek had offered just the tool she needed.

Dodging the huge fists, Lodestar took aim at the construct's knees, ensuring Cold Shoulder's actual body was nowhere near them. Firing off beams of energy at precisely the same intensity as what she'd been receiving, she saw cracks form immediately. The entire thing tottered precariously to the left for several seconds.

"Being big and strong is useful, but it also makes you the easiest target. Reinforce your weak points, or change the design to get around them."

Just as Lodestar prepared to knock her over, Medley rushed in from the side. She readied for another flurry—only, this was different. Instantly gone were the wild, animalistic strikes. Suddenly, Medley was holding himself carefully, entire body tense and waiting, even his tail extended, ready to attack. He came with a pair of punches that fell short, only for that tail to whip around and catch Lodestar in the leg. While the blow wasn't powerful enough to earn a serious reaction, he'd still scored it.

"Not bad, although I wish you'd started off like this. Would have let me see more of what you can do." Eyes darting to Hat Trick, Lodestar noted that while she was staying low, the team's fourth member was still crawling

steadily closer to the boulder. If she fired at this angle, Lodestar was most likely to hit Hat Trick's head—much too dangerous for a simple evaluation. But if she flew over, Medley and Cold Shoulder would have a clear path to the boulder. Once someone made contact, her job grew far more difficult.

“Now!”

She heard the order ring out just before she saw Medley drop into a ball, covering his ears and eyes. Turning, Lodestar made it just in time to witness Cold Shoulder falling out of the ice in the same position as Medley. That was all she got before the giant ball of light overhead exploded.

This had to be something from a video game. No real-world item created a perfect sphere of noise and sound, crashing over victims in an effort to leave them helpless. Add in that it had clearly been fired from the ridge where Cyber Geek was perched, and the explanation was almost too obvious. None of it actually worked on Lodestar, of course, but based on what she knew of the others, they'd definitely be feeling the effects.

Still, even with an attack like this, Medley's regeneration meant the impacted ears and eyes would heal rapidly, especially from such superficial damage. They'd earned roughly ten seconds of “stunned” Lodestar with that maneuver.

Medley was the first up, to no one's surprise. He motioned to Hat Trick, who hopped up from the ground and sprinted for all she was worth. This was it, then. The muscle races in to occupy her, while Cyber Geek adds to the pressure with his ranged skills. Hat Trick comes running, knowing she'll be spotted, and gains ground slowly while the distraction team keeps up its work. When they can't hold the line anymore, Cyber Geek launches the stunning blast, giving Hat Trick a window of opportunity to make the big play. If she got the boulder inside that hat, they'd be able to move it with no concern for weight.

While those two moved, Cold Shoulder leapt into action. Freed from her construct, she immediately fired blue energy at Lodestar, sealing the living legend to the ground and weighing her down with as much ice as possible. Smart: more delay, even when the stunning effects faded. It was a good, sound strategy overall.

The only trouble was, the team didn't quite grasp their own strength. Much as she disliked this part, Lodestar had to impart the lesson—otherwise some criminal would, and not in so nearly kind a manner. With the ten seconds up, Lodestar sprang into action.

“Medley’s recovery means that even at full blast, the lightshow has already lost effect.” She tore loose from the ice, slamming Cold Shoulder once in the gut, sending her tumbling over. “That was your strength I used to break free and hit you back. Don’t make yourself vulnerable in a fight unless there’s a true need for it. Most enemies won’t give you a chance to recover.”

With a burst of speed, she flew over to Medley, slamming him to the ground. She landed heavy, buying herself some time with fewer opponents. “Cyber Geek has some rapid movement options, too, making it easy to get around the battlefield.”

That only left Lodestar and Hat Trick for the moment, the latter covered in dirt and panting from her undignified crawl. Lodestar respected that appearance; it was the look of someone who chose victory over vanity. In a way, she hated to do this. Showing the martial ones their failings was educational; she wasn’t sure what lessons Hat Trick could take from this exchange.

“It was a good effort,” Lodestar said. “Much more competent than most teams manage on their first go-round.”

“Maybe so, but we aren’t here to put in a ‘good effort.’ We’re here to give everything.” Hat Trick reached into her pocket and produced a classic magician’s wand, black with two white tips. It was the element of her powers she’d used the least, which meant Lodestar had minimal information on what that magical implement was capable of.

Lodestar darted forward, just as Hat Trick exclaimed, “Doveakazam!”

An explosion of birds blasted Lodestar in the face, white feathers smacking into her nose and mouth, causing genuine annoyance, if not pain. She hacked and spit as the avian attack dissipated, her attention broken until the last of them cleared. By the time she could see properly, Hat Trick was nearly on top of her, a deck of cards in her hand.

“Fifty-two hundred pickup!”

A torrent of playing cards washed over Lodestar, like a firehose of rectangular plastic. The deck either didn’t end or had some other enchanted elements, as card after card battered Lodestar’s vision. All the others had gone for damage, whereas Hat Trick, their supposed runner, was using distraction. Something was wrong. She’d missed a detail, and it tickled the edge of her brain as she lunged forward, grabbing Hat Trick’s wrists and angling the stream of cards away.



“Impressive,” Lodestar admitted. “That first one genuinely took me off balance for a few moments.”

“Thanks. I’m not much of a magician yet, but I have worked really hard on mastering the most important part.”

Her hat was gone. That’s what was off. As Lodestar looked down at the cape named Hat Trick, clasped in her grip, Lodestar noticed that the meta-magician’s most distinctive accessory was missing. Spinning around, Lodestar realized something else a hair too late. She hadn’t gotten shot in a few minutes.

Already knowing what was waiting for her, Lodestar saw Cyber Geek land a few feet from the boulder, the giant jumping boot dissolving back into electricity and numbers. He scooped up the unmistakable top hat from where it was sliding gently along the icy ground, slamming his hand against the boulder to establish physical contact.

“Misdirection,” Lodestar muttered. “The heart of illusion is misdirection. But now, it’s just a matter of catching him before he hauls it across the line.”

Even as she was speaking, Lodestar caught something else. Cyber Geek wasn’t trying to put the boulder in the hat. Instead, he held his hand out underneath it. Hat Trick wiggled in her grip, making some sort of motion, and a silver device fell from the hat into Cyber Geek’s extended hand.

Not knowing what it could do, Lodestar opted to sprint. They’d clearly built their strategy around making this part work, so she had to assume it would end the session. To her own shock, Lodestar realized something as she ran: they’d baited her out to just the right distance. While she might be able to cross this far in a blink, none of *them* were fast enough to do the same. They’d estimated their own best speed, and specifically worked to draw her out farther than that. She definitely couldn’t knock this group on self-analysis.

Pushing as fast as she felt appropriate, Lodestar rushed forward while Cyber Geek wrapped his arm around the boulder and pressed the silver device. There was a flash of purple, and suddenly, he was gone, along with the stone sphere. An identical flash appeared over on the ridge where Cyber Geek had been shooting from, and seconds later, she saw him leap from the edge, boulder clutched in his hands as jets fired from the *Blaster Bros* armor. From that far back, he easily cleared the line before Lodestar could even properly lift off the ground.

“Cyber Geek has an item that splits in two, and lets you jump back to wherever you leave the anchor. The issue was that it had a ten-second timer, but objects in my hat come out the same way they go in. Down to the second.” Hat Trick was dusting herself off as Medley and Cold Shoulder staggered to their feet, shaking off those last blows. “Was that okay? Are we allowed to combine powers like that?”

“Not only are you allowed, it’s exactly the sort of thinking these evaluations are meant to encourage,” Lodestar replied. Awareness of their own abilities, and that of their team, to the point where they’d started developing combination techniques. While they might be low on raw power, this group had worked on their coordination to an incredible degree.

Floating up into the sky, Lodestar saw the crowd milling around Cyber Geek and his prize: the boulder, dragged barely past the line in the ground. “Attention, everyone: the team of Cold Shoulder, Cyber Geek, Hat Trick, and Medley has successfully retrieved their target! Big round of congratulations to our opening group. I know it’s never easy to be the first in a situation like this one. Everyone else, take five minutes to update your plans based on what you just saw while I reset the stage.”

She looked down, noting the looks of hope and determination. Now that they knew victory could be achieved, that should make for some bolder, interesting plays in the evaluations to come. Perhaps a part of her was excited by that. Playing with limited stakes was the closest she got to a challenge anymore. No harm in enjoying herself, so long as the education and evaluation continued to come first.

“After that, have the next team ready to go. Our day is only getting started.”

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## Chapter 46

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Deep down, Ivan had always known this day would come. In a world of secret identities and masks, he'd long ago learned that few things truly stayed hidden forever. Part of him had even imagined giving the talk to his children when they became adults in an attempt to get ahead of the eventual revelation. He wondered if he'd have really had the strength to go through with it, or if this was always the way it would have gone down: backed into telling the truth, his hand forced, the secret pried from his grip.

He and Rick sat in the living room, Ivan in a chair, his son on the couch. They both had drinks in front of them, because Ivan had needed to fill the minutes between getting Janet's call and her dropping off Rick. That had been a hell of a half hour, picturing what it would be like to come clean, all the horrified reactions it might garner. Yet upon Rick's arrival, they'd fallen into silence. Both knew what came next, and neither felt entirely sure of how to proceed.

Ultimately, Ivan pushed things forward. He was the parent. It was his job to take the harder role. "Your mother told me you have questions, and she let me know what they were about. I don't want to lie you, son. I've never wanted to lie to you. What you're digging near isn't something minor, though. I hope you can understand that. But I also don't see what's to be gained by lying at this point. So, here is my bargain: I'll answer the questions you ask. There will be details I might leave out, and I think that once we're deep enough in for you to really grasp the situation, you'll understand why. That said, there is a caveat to this. What we discuss here

can be talked about with your mother, and no one else. Especially not Beth.”

Rick bristled, pulling his back up straight. “She’s your daughter. If I have a right to know, then so does she.”

“Beth is twelve years old, a child; she is in no way ready to grapple with this kind of topic.” Ivan didn’t need to sit straighter; he’d already been positioned properly from the start. “This is nonnegotiable. What we’re going to discuss could put you in serious danger if the wrong people found out. You have to promise me, Rick. Look me in the eyes and swear you will not tell anyone else about this. After the fuss you’ve kicked up over me keeping you in the dark, I can’t imagine you’d be hypocrite enough to break your word.”

The stubbornness in Ivan was reflected back at him in Rick’s eyes. For a moment, he thought obstinance would win the day and the whole talk would fall apart; however, Rick also had his mother’s skill for seeing the bigger picture. Swallowing his annoyance at being forced into something, he met Ivan’s gaze. “I promise, what we talk about here stays between me, you, and Mom. Maybe also a therapist, depending on how bad it is.”

“That’s a reasonable concession, and I know some people if it comes to that,” Ivan agreed. “All right, what do you want to know?”

“Who are you?”

That came fast; it had been on a hair trigger. Ivan considered the question, and how to honestly answer it while still easing Rick into all of this. “Ivan Gerhardt. The first name came from the monsters who raised me, the second was chosen by the first real friend I ever made. I’m a manager at Vendallia Industries, father to two children, and as of a few weeks ago, a Starscout cluster leader.” He paused. That was part of who he was, and for a time, it would have been the whole truth. But even if he counted Fornax as who he’d been, there was still Pseudonym, who’d been too active as of late to entirely discount.

“Past that... I work with an organization that helps recovering criminals. Let’s leave that there for the moment; it might be easier to discuss once some of the other holes are filled in.”

There was a sheen of sweat on Rick’s forehead, despite the climate control in the townhouse. He rubbed his hands on his jeans, wiping away more perspiration. That question had been an easy one. He was still gathering courage for what he deemed truly scary.

“And who is Tori Rivas?”

“No.” Ivan halted the conversation midstride. “Who I am, what I’ve done—these are things that might impact your life, so I concede that you have a right to know them. The secrets of others don’t fall under that umbrella. Tori is a friend and a coworker, someone I trust. Anything past that you can find out by asking her directly, though I’m not sure I would recommend it.”

The denial had brought Rick up short, but Ivan had left him little room for rebuttal. More hand-wiping, a little frantic now. Reaching over, Ivan put a hand on his son’s shoulder. “Ask me whatever it is that’s eating at you. You’ll feel better when it’s out.”

“That’s not the impression I got from Mom,” Rick muttered under his breath. “Guess there’s no point in avoiding it. I want to know what happened at the beach. I don’t know which one, but when I was around four or five—”

“You were five. It was a small coastal town named Sandshire, down in Florida. We used to go there on family trips. Janet’s parents took her there as a child. It was something of a tradition. I liked that town.”

When Ivan’s pause stretched into true silence, Rick leaned forward. “Interesting as that is, it’s not the part I’m asking about. What happened there? Why do I start to freak out when I think about it too much? Why can’t I remember anything besides flashes of purple in the water?”

No more room for dodging. It was time to start giving Rick what he thought he wanted.

“While we were at the beach that day, some creatures appeared. A new species created by the Carp Conqueror, this aquatic, meta-human criminal with dreams of grandeur. They were mounting an assault, you see. Trying to take over the land-world, as they phrased it. In the end, none of the details really mattered that much. They made a very crucial mistake early on that sent it all to hell. They threatened my family.”

He could still feel the warm air as Carp Conqueror’s odd, wet laughter echoed over the sounds of fleeing beachgoers. First came the offer: help lead the charge. Then came the mistake: daring to cast a finger at Ivan’s then-wife and children, implying they might not survive the tide that would wash along the lands. Ivan couldn’t remember things so well from that point on, just snippets. The rest of the details required diving into the Fornax side of himself, which this was definitely not the time for.

“What did you do, when they threatened us?” Rick was leaning forward so far, Ivan feared he might tumble from the couch. The poor boy looked ready to pop from nerves. This must have been eating at him for a long time.

“I neutralized the threat.”

“That’s not an answer! Tell me what happened already. Dad, please.”

With a quiet farewell to the simple, normal relationship they’d had, Ivan forced himself to tell Rick the truth.

“I slaughtered them all. One by one. First, they died fighting. Then, they died begging. By the end, it mostly just screams. I tried to be quick, as merciful as possible, but when dealing with a new anatomy, you have to pulp everything to be sure they’re dead. Within three minutes, the water was stained with their oozing purple blood.”

It was a strange progression, the emotions on Rick’s face. Relief swept in, brief and beautiful, as his father’s words confirmed that Rick wasn’t, in fact, crazy. Then came the horror as the implications followed. With every word, the point was driven home harder, and the possibility that it was all a joke shrank. By the end, Rick no longer looked like he’d swallowed a live bee. Instead, he was growing pale, staring at Ivan like he’d unveiled himself as the avatar of Death itself. Which wasn’t as far from the truth as Ivan might have liked.

“What you’re feeling right now is natural, son. The shock. The disbelief. The terror at what it all means. Understand this: it only gets harder from here. If the truth is really what you want, make sure you’re ready to hear it. We don’t need to do all of this in a single round.”

The expression on Rick’s face grew more neutral as his mind went to work, properly adding in this new information to whatever he’d already been working with. “If you really killed an invading force of meta-humans, does that mean you have powers?”

“Yes. Though not the kind that can be passed down. They’re nothing like your sister’s—those truly are a mystery. I’ve got a few tricks, but by and large, I mostly lean on my physical skills.”

“Kind of bummer. I was really hoping graceful aging was part of our genetics,” Rick admitted. He was falling into a familiar pattern with his dad, momentarily forgetting the revelation. Ivan could actually see when it popped up again in his perception; Rick’s whole body shifted to a closed-off position. “Must be pretty strong, to kill that many.”

“Slaughtered,” Ivan corrected. “You can’t call that meager resistance they offered a fight. I was a blade cutting through a field of wheat. Yes, Rick. I am strong. Not what I once was, but still quite dangerous.”

Rick was retreating a bit now, pushing into the couch’s back cushions. “If you killed that many people, shouldn’t you have gone to jail?”

“Details matter. I pushed back an army that was invading our soil and publicly declaring war. Can’t prosecute on that without setting a dangerous standard for the capes.”

The room was growing tense. Reality had started to sink in for Rick. His father was a killer: proud and efficient, at that. Still, the boy had courage. He pushed on, determined to get his answers.

“Is that why I can’t remember? It was so bad I had to block it out?”

“Partially, but you had some magical assistance.” Ivan reached into his pocket and produced a small crystal bottle with pink liquid inside. “This potion helps you forget things you don’t want to remember. We gave you some that night, after hours of hysterical crying and fits. You saw something unimaginably terrible, and worse, you saw it committed by someone you loved. It would have been a lifelong trauma, so we gave you an out. But magic is tied to willpower, and the more you tried to remember, the weaker the effects became.”

“Are... are you going to make me drink that?” There was nothing subtle about it now. Rick was visibly moving further down the couch, away from Ivan.

Carefully, Ivan picked the bottle back up and tucked it away. “I was going to offer it, though that seems like a no. Even if I did force you to drink it, that wouldn’t matter. As I said, it helps you forget things you don’t want to remember. It could never do more than what you desired.”

“Oh, yeah, I’m sure at age five I was making great decisions about which memories I might need to hang on to. And how convenient that keeping your secret worked out to be the best thing for me.”

Much as Ivan wanted to smack that train of thought aside, this was already a precarious situation. Anything less than true honesty in the moment might do more damage than could ever be mended, especially with the issue of eroded trust.

“In my heart, I really do believe that you were better off forgetting. But I’m far from a perfect person. It’s very possible I allowed my own selfish desires to cloud my judgment on the issue. Because you’re right, Rick. I

didn't want you to stay that way. You wouldn't even get in the car with me. You screamed and screamed if I even came close. That... *this*... was the last thing I ever wanted."

"For me to know the truth?" Even through the anger Rick was trying to project, Ivan could still see the true emotion lurking in his gaze.

"For my child to be afraid of me. For you to think, even for a moment, that I would ever hurt you, turn that side of myself in your direction. Almost everyone who knows me is scared of what I can do, what I represent—sometimes, just me in general. Not you two. You ran to me for comfort whenever you were scared or hurt. You understood that there was nothing in this world I wouldn't do to keep you safe."

Ivan stared at the fear in Rick's face, the terror he'd seen so many times in so many expressions. Never had it cut him so deeply. Things were going to be different from now on, but that didn't mean he wouldn't still try his best for as long as there was parenting left to do. "Whatever you're thinking and feeling about this, understand that fundamentally, nothing has changed. To you, the discoveries are new; however, I've been this man all along. I'm the same Ivan you've known your whole life. It's just that now, I'm also more. None of that matters more to me than being your dad. I would tear the moon in half to keep you from harm."

To Ivan's surprise, Rick uncoiled from his ball in the corner of the couch slightly. The boy looked dazed, and no wonder. With the roller coaster of emotions he was on, his brain was probably fried. After a moment of consideration, he spoke in a more controlled voice than any sixteen year old should be able to manage, given the circumstances.

"I think I need a break. We're not done. I want to know the rest, just maybe... not today."

"A wise decision. One step at a time is the surest way to walk the path you're on." Ivan started forward to comfort Rick, but stopped when he caught the wince. No mistaking it, the shadow of fear now lay between them.

Even though it broke his heart, Ivan pretended not to notice. That was his burden as the parent. And he intended to play that role for however long Rick would still let him. However, Ivan had a sinking suspicion that those days were severely limited.



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## Chapter 47

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Tori hadn't been to the main offices of Indigo Technologies before. She'd robbed a lab they owned, worked in a subsidiary, and rubbed elbows with the owner at the guild; however, she'd never had occasion to come see Wade Wyatt in the most official capacity of his civilian identity.

What amazed her from the moment she touched foot in the lobby was the security, and the knowledge of how few people would be able to spot it. Sonic disruptor cannons masquerading as modern art, pulse bombs worked into the pot of every lush plant in the space—even the floor tiles gave off the telltale sheen of electro-bind coating. Nothing here was entirely what it seemed, nor designed to serve only one purpose. Wade had built a fortress and made it look exactly as bland and unassuming as every other corporate office she'd had the misfortune to end up inside. Outside of the high-tech defenses, it was still aesthetically pleasing, if one went in for that sort of thing: lots of metal and glass, loads of natural light.

Today it hosted a fairly brisk crowd despite it being Saturday afternoon. After a morning whipping up some samples, Tori hoped she had enough progress to bring before Wade. It made sense to knock this out early—no point in redoing the work that was already out there—but she also felt somewhat underprepared. Perhaps she should have waited until there was a fully functional prototype. She shook the thought from her head. They needed to act fast, while Tori was still a news item. Once the spotlight faded, this became less effective.

At least on that front, there was little need for concern. She'd caught sight of several photographers lurking near her apartment, though they

seemed hesitant to get too close. Given the phrases Chloe used whenever she spotted one, the paparazzi probably thought it was cursed by some meta, which actually wasn't too far from the truth. It wasn't enough to deter them entirely, a fact that Tori found annoying overall, but would be useful in the short term. She'd even made sure not to slip away when coming here. Let them speculate what she was up to. It would only add more attention when she made her move.

Making her way through the plush lobby, Tori strolled up to security, a thick-necked man with a sharp look in his wary eyes.

He glanced up, taking in her oil-stained jeans and t-shirt that was only slightly cleaner. "Name and appointment?" No sense of judgment, which she supposed did track. Working in a cutting-edge tech firm, he'd no doubt seen plenty of the type who put work above things like fashion or hygiene.

"Tori Rivas, here to see Mr. Wade Wyatt."

She'd been braced for skepticism, a furtive glance to be sure this really was the name on the appointment list. Not so much as a flicker. He absorbed the name like he'd been waiting all day to hear it.

"Identification." He held out a hand, into which she deposited her driver's license.

The problem, Tori quickly realized, was that she'd been thinking of this encounter like she was visiting someone high in the company. But Wade wasn't high, he was the top. They knew *his* visitors' names already; those were likely memorized as soon as the appointment was logged.

"Come with me." Handing back her license, the guard hefted himself up, walking around the side of the thick security desk that Tori noticed was covertly reinforced. Something told her these guards were more than mere muscle, but then, she'd be reckless to assume anything different, knowing where she was.

Together, they walked past the first bay of elevators, where a crowd of people in expensive clothing waited to board. They continued through a locked door that the guard buzzed them past, into a small, lush room with another guard and a single elevator.

Unlike her first one, there was nothing front-desk appropriate about this guard. He was bald, with tattoos running up and down his flesh. There was something else, impossible to put her finger on. Tori could simply smell her own kind. This one had seen danger. He might even be a guild member she had yet to encounter.

The first guard left as soon as he'd deposited her, hustling back to his desk. Her new escort rose slowly from his chair. His eyes were virtually peeling her, scanning for any danger, threat, or other potential issue. Finally, after a full minute of wordless staring, he reached over and tapped the elevator's button.

"Go ahead." His voice was raspy, but surprisingly warm.

"Thanks. Do civilians get to meet you, too, or is it only the folks using my channels?"

In response, the tattoos flowed across his skin, stretching and warping, even rising from the flesh. Seconds later, she was looking at a respectably dressed fellow in a well-tailored business suit. "I give them the professional face. It's uncomfortable to keep up, though, so I didn't bother with you." With a release of effort, the tattoos shifted back to their starting positions.

"Neat. Got a name I should know?"

He shook his head just as the elevator dinged its arrival. "If you ever get my name, it means you've royally screwed up. Or we're friends, I suppose."

One of those, then. Not a shocker, given the role he was filling in his downtime. Tori wasn't surprised. She'd seen Ivan get dispatched to slaughter an entire gang who'd crossed them; she was well aware the guild had operations like that. Still, didn't hurt to sow her own seeds of danger, while she was around.

"Then I hope I get it the friendly way. And to prove it, I'll give you a piece of friendly advice: if I ever do fuck up, don't try to come calling. Let's just say someone already has dibs on that particular task, and they aren't the sort of person you want to jump in line."

"Warning noted. Good luck with your meeting." Those were the last words before the elevator doors whispered shut.

The chrome elevator moved fast, especially considering how tall the building was. In shockingly short order, another ding sounded her arrival. The top floor of Indigo Technologies: the office of one man, Wade Wyatt. It was strange that Tori felt nervous, like she was meeting him for the first time again. She'd known him for months now... except, that wasn't quite true. Tori knew Doctor Mechaniacal. She and Wade Wyatt had barely interacted. Those dynamics were always different, and she'd never been especially adept at rolling with social challenges.

Putting the doubt out of mind, Tori strolled onward through a set of frosted glass doors that could likely withstand a missile and into the large waiting area outside Wade's office. It was filled with high-end furniture that also still managed to be comfortable—greater proof than anyone should need that Wade was a super-genius inventor.

Sitting at a vast, white stone desk, was one of the most unassuming women Tori had ever laid eyes on. Short, curly hair that already looked disheveled despite so much of the day remaining, an oversized cardigan with intentional cats and unintentional cat-hair as decoration upon it, huge glasses that evoked the image of a dragonfly—she looked like the person who'd be trailing after her boss with an armful of falling receipts and a cup of half-spilled coffee.

Tori was immediately suspicious. Big, musclebound guard? That made sense. So did the scary dude watching the elevator. But this? This set off every villain instinct Tori had. All those checks to make it this far, and the woman Wade had running the actual entry point was a normal, put-upon secretary? When someone worked that hard to appear mundane, it usually meant they had a hell of a secret tucked up their sleeve.

Approaching with care, Tori put on her most respectful voice. "Good afternoon. I have an appointment with Mr. Wyatt."

The secretary whipped her head up like she'd just noticed Tori's entrance, large eyes made even bigger by those comically oversized glasses. As she leapt up, her knees smacked the underside of the desk, eliciting what had to be a painful *thump* underneath.

"Of course! Miss Rivas. Security radioed to let us know you'd be heading up. Wade will be done in a few moments, just some private work to wrap up now that he knows you're here. Can I get you anything while you wait? Water, soda—we even have one of those fancy coffee machines in the breakroom."

"A water would be great." Much as she might like a bit of caffeine, her nerves were cranked up as things stood. Better to stay calm for what came next, and besides, she didn't want to be a bother. Not with someone this suspicious.

From somewhere under the desk, her greeter popped open a concealed fridge and produced a small, cold bottle. "Have a seat anywhere you like, and if you need anything, just give me a shout. Name is Dolores, and it's a pleasure to meet you."

Handing over the bottle, along with a handshake, Tori accepted both, then retreated to a white leather couch to wait for her appointment. She kept one eye on the door and one eye on Dolores, not quite sure what to expect from either.



Not a bad day so far. After the first team succeeded, Lodestar had stopped three in a row before the next team scored victory. Of that failing batch, she'd probably still promote one of them up to harder tasks; their failing had been execution more than planning, and that was an easier fix. Interestingly, despite kicking up a fuss at the outset, the New Science Sentries hadn't taken a turn yet.

Lodestar already knew why; she could practically hear Professor Quantum's voice ringing in their heads. He'd have told them to make a strong impression, so if they couldn't open the show, they'd try to close it. First or last: both tended to stick in people's minds the most when they did something memorable. Of course, that was precisely the sort of thinking that was holding the New Science Sentries back, so perhaps this would be a good chance to demonstrate their failings.

They weren't a bad team, not by a long shot. They were just working to catch up with everyone else. Because Professor Quantum had taught them his way, via the old methods, he'd built a team on pure strength and crowd appeal. Everyone else had come up through the new system, where the focus was placed on being the most effective superhero possible, especially when it came to protecting civilians. Until they thought about their image second and the job first, they would always end up a step behind.

It galled her to imagine what sorts of feats those four could accomplish if they'd been properly instructed. With their power, they should be knocking out tasks several degrees past what anyone else here could be saddled with. Given how stressed the AHC was getting as it was pulled in direction after direction, she could have really used the help, too. Thankfully, after this evaluation, there would be a few more to pitch in. Perhaps the New Science Sentries would be among them. She'd have to see what sorts of tactics they employed.

On the other hand, part of her felt bad for the team. This evaluation was going to be harder for them than anyone else, because their collective abilities were that much more powerful. Between Tachyonic's speed, Agent Quantum's toughness, and Plasmodia's raw power, Lodestar would have a lot more juice to wield during their session.

The five-minute rest was almost over, so Lodestar called out a quick warning, letting the next team know they'd be starting soon. There shouldn't be a whole lot of teams left; they had to be getting near the end. Once this was done, she'd have a debrief with Quorum to get his impressions—he'd been watching the whole ordeal back at base—then a few hours of patrol, and home to pick up Penelope. Ivan had said he might swing by, as well, so that meant a decent meal she didn't have to—

A blast of searing energy tore across the battlefield, on a direct course for Lodestar. Having been lost in thought, she sped up her perception and considered for a moment whether it was appropriate to dodge or take the shot head-on. Once Lodestar realized who was firing, though, the decision became simple. Using speed on par with Tachyonic's, she zipped aside from Plasmodia's blast, arriving at the boulder a split second before Presto appeared just above it.

"Out of the gate, Big Fini—hrrrmphh!" Presto's declaration of success was cut short as Lodestar's hand wrapped around the back of his skull before he could lay a finger on their prize.

"I'm pretty sure you can deal with this, but call if you need help." Lodestar grabbed Presto by the belt on the back of his costume, her free hand still holding his skull, which was pointed directly up to the open sky. "You've got a whip-smart mind under there, so try being less predictable. Also, while teleportation is great, yours is limited to line of sight. So don't ever let yourself get into a position like this one."

With that, Lodestar hurled Presto into the sky, face first. He would eventually manage to spin around, hopefully killing off his momentum and recovering, but this would buy her some time without having to watch for rips in space.

She could already see Tachyonic racing across the field, with Agent Quantum following behind at a considerable distance. It was time for Lodestar to test the New Science Sentries.

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## Chapter 48

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She wasn't kept waiting long. In under ten minutes, Wade called for her, and Dolores ushered Tori into an office with aspirations of being a museum. All along the walls were famous designs and inventions from great minds through history. Some were from the pre-meta creators—Tori spotted a Da Vinci diagram in a proud place of honor among the displays. There were also stranger, clearly meta bits: harder to identify, unless one was the sort of person who knew which meta first discovered and broke the Althusian temporal limits. Wade had even displayed a pile of ashes labeled "Edison Contracts." Apparently, he held history's great credit-thief in the same regard as most educated inventors. Tori could identify nearly every piece displayed in the huge office; she might be a woman of few passions, but this was definitely one of them.

In the center of the room sat the man whose own creations outshone the displays by orders of magnitude. What Wade had built could have quite literally changed the world. Part of this meeting was to find out why it was that he hadn't, in fact, done just that. Tori was smart enough to clock that there had been several great meta-geniuses through the decades, some on the side of capes, some on the side of villains, yet the amount of technology available to the public remained steady: a slow, gradual increase like one would expect in normal development, with only a few errant spikes. That couldn't be a coincidence, and much like the guild's code, Tori needed to know the rules before she started playing the game. Not because she necessarily planned to abide by them, but because it was important to know

where the lines were. Breaking rules worked best when it was intentional, not due to ignorance.

“Tori, a pleasure to see you,” Wade greeted her. He rose from his desk to shake her hand, then settled immediately back into his lush chair. She took one of the pair in front of his desk while Wade continued. “The room is fortified, secured, and warded, so feel free to speak plainly. In these walls, I keep a tight schedule; we don’t have time for double-talk. Now then, Ivan said you wanted to consult with Indigo Technologies on something. I’m going to be straightforward: I took this meeting out of courtesy and respect, but understand that it is very unlikely I’m going to bring something from that world into this one. Splitting them apart is how I protect both.”

Concise, informative, and bluntly honest; it was so nice to be dealing with a fellow science-minded colleague. Much faster than playing the societal games of small talk and niceties.

Reaching into her bag, Tori produced a small vial of green liquid, a small circular device, and a stack of pages covered in scrawling and sketches. “Go ahead and look over the specs while I explain. You’ll be able to figure them out quickly.” Making sure she had everything set out, Tori started on the pitch she may or may not have rehearsed a few times in the mirror that morning. “I’ve been thinking about what to do with my newfound sense of celebrity. There’s no getting around it, not for some time, and while I was originally tempted to hole up and hope it faded, I’ve been considering another tactic. One to make use of the attention.”

Wade’s face creased in momentary confusion as he flipped through the pages, then vanished as he found whatever detail had eluded him. Tori kept on going, sure that he was still taking in every word. “I’ve made no bones about what my long-term goals are. I want to build my own company, turn my designs into reality. For a long time, that was it—I just knew I wanted that place to exist. But now, I think I’m starting to see the shape of it: a market I can serve, a need I can fill, and a way to leverage all this bad luck into exactly the right launching platform.”

After one last scan, Wade put the pages down. “The device is interesting, though not especially groundbreaking in complexity. I find the compound you intend to fill it with far more fascinating, if it works as described. But what I find most interesting of all is that you’ve brought me such a proposal in the first place. Miss Rivas, outside of Ivan, there is likely



no one in the guild who is more familiar with your past than me, so I am *keenly* aware of the lengths you've gone to avoid putting your work or trust in the hands of other people. To have you suddenly show up, asking for what I'm assuming to be help, if not outright partnership, is a tad confusing."

He wasn't wrong. Tori's entire history was essentially example after example of fucking herself out of potential opportunities to avoid situations almost exactly like this one: handing off her work to a huge corporation to do whatever they pleased. Even now, the notion riled up part of her, causing a brief churn in her stomach. Thankfully, because it was such an obvious point, Tori had come prepared with an answer.

"Part of it is me learning from the guild. If I truly took nothing else from my education, I saw that even the most powerful metas need people they trust to lean on. And the guild is also why I'm taking it to you. Frankly, if you were a normal business, this would be a non-starter, but I would hope there's going to be a level of respect here not present in most business dealings. Past all that, though, you're right: this is still very hard for me to do. That's why I brought you the product and pitch that I did. Alone, that's a neat gadget, one I'm sure you could easily rip off. It's only when you pair it with me that it becomes a highly marketable asset."

Wade lifted an eyebrow. She'd captured his interest. "Explain."

In response, Tori's expression shifted. She wasn't much of an actor, but she could tap into real feelings well enough. There was no shortage of rage to be had at any moment, a lasting gift from the tragedy of her childhood, yet today, she needed something harder to show. Tori permitted a touch of fear onto her face, along with the rising tide of fury.

"When those bastards took me off the street, I felt helpless, like many of you out there watching have felt. Self-defense classes, training, awareness: I did everything right, and I still got snatched. The capes made it in time, sure, but what if they hadn't? How long are we going to trust our safety to people who might show up, if you're lucky? I'm tired of feeling helpless. Tired of being afraid. That's why I've partnered with Indigo Technologies to develop the Rivas line of personal defense devices. Non-lethal, unobtrusive tech designed to get you out of danger right away, not force you to wait for when a cape happens to be around."

Understanding came swiftly. It wasn't an especially obtuse concept, especially for a mind like Wade Wyatt's. He muddled it over for several

seconds, lifting up the vial of green liquid and turning it around in his hands. What he was searching for, she had no idea. All Tori could do was wait as he contemplated the proposal.

“It’s not just the tech, it’s the sales pitch. The capes got caught with their pants down on the civilian side, and as the first public kidnapping in so many years, you have a unique platform to speak on the failings of relying on superheroes. Based on the designs, you’ve got quite a few ways to weave these into compact mirrors, so I take it to mean we’re targeting a predominantly female demographic, which would make your story all the more compelling.”

“We *start* with a targeted demographic, then grow it outward,” Tori corrected. “Beginning there will play the best, given what happened to me. Then there’s Beverly’s designs, and the fact that women over forty are currently the audience buying the least Indigo Technologies products. This gets you a way into their pockets and starts building brand loyalty. I didn’t come in here expecting a handout. This strategy opens up doors to a whole new market.”

“Yes, I see you have quite a developed plan. So developed, in fact, I wonder where it is that I fit in. Your prototype is rough, yet plainly on the right path, and if this compound does as indicated, it will be extremely effective. You have the funds from your museum caper to handle the build, and national attention for free press. What do you need from Indigo?”

Despite Wade’s assurances, Tori still swept the room, making sure no one was around to overhear them. “Resources would help speed this along while I’m still a hot topic, but more than that, I need guidance. I’ve seen what you can build versus what you release. There’s obviously some sort of unspoken cap on the technology we let out into the world. I kept this one as basic as possible to be safe, but more complex ideas will demand more complex designs. I don’t want to start off with the FBI up my ass because I released some gizmo with a forbidden latch.”

Wade snickered, hiding it poorly behind his hand.

“Yes, I’m sure a *latch* is the device you’d want to squeeze more tech into. You aren’t wrong, Miss Rivas, there are certain checks to ensure humanity doesn’t get tech it isn’t prepared for; however, a fair amount of it is simply the fact that the best inventors also have secret lives. I hold my top work back for the guild, because to release it publicly would make it available to my enemies. Same for Professor Quantum, and Tyranny... I

presume.” Wade didn’t look uncertain often, yet at the mention of the mysterious ruler, his brow creased for a flicker of a moment.

Part of Tori wished Tyranny had greater affiliation with the guild. All she knew of the woman were rumors, admittedly, but they were quite impressive rumors nevertheless: genius inventor who ruled an entire island nation with the strength of her mind and the power of her creations. Were her work more public, Tori might have picked a different inventing idol, but it was Doctor Mechanical whose creations were on display for all to see during his criminal enterprises. The same person she was on the verge of partnering with for a project, something Tori was actively working to keep from getting overly excited about.

Wade soon continued. “Occasionally, some inventor will start dealing matter liquidators out of a van, but they never have the reach or infrastructure to last long, and reverse engineering meta-tech is essentially a discipline in itself, one that very few have mastered. That is to say, it will be some time before you brush against the real technological ceiling; however, you should still give careful thought to the products you create. To steal one of Ivan’s favorite turns of phrase: think of it like you’re baking a cake. Once something goes in the mix, you can’t take it out. Introduce new technology to society, and there’s no undo function. Accidentally wreck an industry or bankrupt a country? Too bad. Whatever happens, you have to live with.”

“That’s an aspect I’ll weigh seriously moving forward,” Tori replied. “But for today, the design in question, do you see any major issues? The big trick there is the liquid, and good luck to anyone who tries to break that down. We can keep it proprietary. Very limited risk it would enter society at large.”

“This one works... in theory.” Wade tapped the half-formed prototype, setting down the vial next to it. “I get why you came to me early. You needed to see if I was on board and had feedback about any lines you were crossing. But if we want to do your pitch, you need something in your hand. Something tangible, to show you mean business. While we’ll need to negotiate the details, I’m open to the idea moving forward. The sooner, the better, though. We need the story to be fresh. Get me a working prototype, and we can see where that leads.”

Tori was so thrilled, she nearly knocked her chair over climbing up to shake his hand. Not only was her idea getting backing, Tori would be

receiving help from one of the few other minds she genuinely admired. As she and Wade grasped hands, however, he continued speaking.

“Once we have that done, you’re going to enroll in business courses. I know some online ones you can squeeze into your spare time. Given your brain, I imagine you’ll be able to clear the coursework at an exceptional rate.”

She kept on shaking, even as the curious demand hit home. “I’m not saying I won’t—you don’t ask for pointless tasks—but do you mind explaining why?”

“Happily. First and foremost, if you intend to run a company one day, you *should* have that education, and potential investors will expect it from someone in such a core leadership role.” He paused, a dark, more Doctor Mechanial look sliding across his face. “The other reason is that if we’re working together, I’m going to do my best to make the project a success. In the course of that, it’s entirely possible you might see my leadership techniques, and we want a ready excuse if anyone asks you where some of your more... creative problem-solving tactics come from.” Those brilliant eyes were shining, countless schemes forming in the mind behind them, each waiting for the right chance to be turned loose.

It had been a long few weeks, with more lows than highs, but standing in Wade’s office, seeing the danger in his eyes, Tori found herself unexpectedly happy about the curious directions her life could often turn.

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## Chapter 49

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With Presto momentarily neutralized, Tachyonic was the next impending threat. He tore along the ground, breaking all sorts of rules of the universe to truck along at impossible speeds, all without destroying the environment or himself. She could see it all, since Lodestar was more or less matching his speed perfectly. It took a touch of effort on her part; the kid was fast, at least when he was using his suit accessories for the power boost. It seemed like not many of the other capes had caught on that Tachyonic needed the help, and evidently, he wasn't going to give the secret away during evaluation. The guy was coming full speed.

Until, he wasn't. At the very end of his approach, Tachyonic suddenly skidded to a halt, digging his feet in to send a massive spray of rubble and dirt at Lodestar's face. It was similar to Hat Trick's move with the doves, except no one on that team had provided Lodestar with access to super-speed. She didn't dart back, though, as he was no doubt predicting. Instead, Lodestar went up, directly over the wave of dirt. Behind, a searing blast of plasma tore through the space where she should have been.

That was impressive. There was no way Plasmodia could track Tachyonic's movements, so they must have both been counting down to make the attacks line up. This was definitely a team accustomed to working together, and their refined techniques showed it. Not that it mattered much when Lodestar went an unexpected direction, but adapting was part of a fight. Besides, by this point, she'd flown against every other team. They should have accounted for the possibility.

Landing in less than a second, Lodestar retook her same position, waiting for Tachyonic to approach. It wasn't much of a delay. He zoomed in the moment Plasmodia missed, launching a series of blows that were fast, efficient, and well-aimed. Lodestar only dodged a few, letting the rest fall ineffectually on her. "Sorry, you're going to need to hit harder if you want to beat Agent Quantum's durability."

"Obviously." With that, Tachyonic hopped back, landing at the side of Agent Quantum, who had just finished an incredibly fast sprint that still left him looking like a slowpoke.

More or less the same composition as the first team, and many that followed, Lodestar realized. One at range, one to grab, two for melee. Would this have been their move if they'd gone first, or were they mimicking a successful team's tactics? There was nothing wrong with learning on the fly; however, testing unfamiliar formations often wasn't worth the tradeoff. Better to stick with what the team could do well.

On that front, Lodestar realized she might not need to worry, as Agent Quantum and Tachyonic launched a perfectly coordinated attack. Tachyonic went low, aiming for her legs and base, while Agent Quantum stayed high, ready to handle her fists and knock her down if she started to fly. An excellent strategy, with both of them holding near-perfect form. If nothing else, Professor Quantum had taught them to fight. Unfortunately, he'd taught them to fight his way, which was part of why Lodestar expected this evaluation to be especially tough on the New Science Sentries.

With a casual movement, Lodestar stepped back, catching Tachyonic as he pulled slightly ahead, hurling his whole body into the charging form of Agent Quantum. The two went down in a spray of limbs, hurrying to untangle themselves.

While they struggled, Lodestar dashed back over to the boulder. A moment later, Presto appeared once more, hands outstretched. "Again, when you suddenly stop screaming and cursing, that tips me off that you've recovered. Be less predictable."

Into the air Presto went once more, a fresh flurry of swears spouting out of his ascending lips.

Another shot of energy rang out, this one weaker and wide. Plasmodia was trying to add pressure, but wasn't sure what to do when the melee attackers fell apart. Their team was built to run like a machine; it didn't

hold up well when cogs started coming loose. Two of said cogs were back on their feet, looking a tad embarrassed about the tumble they'd taken.

"I can tell you your problem right now," Lodestar informed them. "You attack from a position of strength."

Tachyonic looked momentarily confused; however, Agent Quantum let the words roll right off of him, his whole mind focused on the task at hand. Single-mindedness could be a boon at times—she'd known Ivan long enough to see that prove useful—but it also limited how much one could adapt in the moment. In this case, it was a positive, as seeing his leader unbothered gave Tachyonic his own sense of assurance back. They weren't getting better, but them fighting while shaken would hardly have improved things either.

Another team attack, though this time, they stayed more in sync, arriving in perfect unison. This tactic was shockingly close to a choreographed dance, two men filling the space of one by expertly weaving in and out of the other's way. For a moment, it was as if Lodestar were fighting a four-armed monster, blows raining in from all directions. The trouble was, no matter how much they worked together, they were still ultimately two separate people. Agent Quantum's fists were too slow, and Tachyonic's were too weak. She let the attack run for several seconds before deciding she'd seen all it had to offer. A single blow to the gut sent Tachyonic staggering back, and with a burst of motion, Lodestar slipped behind Agent Quantum, knocking him off balance with a hard strike to the spine.

"You're used to fighting people weaker than you, *maybe* ones on your level. When Professor Quantum tests you against harder opponents, they're always mechanical, and not the sentient type. That means they're limited, predictable, easy to defeat once you learn their patterns."

A rapid series of shots from Plasmodia tore through the air, ones that Lodestar easily sidestepped, seemingly unbothered. "This might feel unfair, but understand, I'm not even using your team's full capabilities right now. If I was hitting with Plasmodia's stopping power, you'd both be down already. Our world isn't balanced in how it gives out abilities. Some get the strength to shake mountains, others can turn soda into water. You cannot assume your position will always be that of the stronger fighter. This is just what it will be like to fight someone who is both fast and strong, a combination you'll eventually find if you fight enough metas."

Tachyonic let out a dusty snicker as he rose to his feet. “You might be right, but it’s a little rich to get that advice coming from Lodestar.”

“I wasn’t born with these powers.” That was all she managed before another blast ripped through the air. Unlike prior shots, this was closer to target, and far more dangerous. A nearby mesa got clipped, resulting in a hole bored through the rock.

Plasmodia was stepping things up... or was she? Come to think of it, Lodestar hadn’t heard much swearing for a few moments. Zipping around to the opposite side of the boulder, she was waiting when Presto appeared, crouched low and with a hand already outstretched.

“A distraction, a new angle of approach, *and* you didn’t even yell a catchphrase? Much better. Keep this up, and you all may just pull off a win.” She thought Presto seemed a tad less surly as she hurled him into the sky yet again, perhaps because he’d been recognized for improving. Knowing Professor Quantum, the kids probably hadn’t gotten much of that during their time under his tutelage.

No sooner was Presto gone than Tachyonic was on her. This time, he’d increased the speed of his punches, hoping to cause enough damage to slow her down, or at least have her put on the act. Since Presto was in the air, Agent Quantum was moving at mortal speeds, and Plasmodia would need time to aim, Lodestar decided this was a fine opportunity for a more personal lesson. Rather than using higher levels of strength, Lodestar dialed in her speed to precisely the same as Tachyonic’s, resulting in a world stuck in slow motion while they moved as normal.

That done, Lodestar didn’t brush aside the coming attacks. Instead, she blocked, returning a jab to Tachyonic’s unprotected ribs. Not enough to take him down: it should feel like a normal blow, meaning that it would hurt without injuring. He appeared momentarily stunned, then came in swinging again. There was some form there, he’d had training, but it was all too evident that he’d grown very used to his speed advantage.

Lodestar easily avoided the wide swing, countering with another short jab, this one directly to Tachyonic’s nose.

“Ow!” He staggered, nearly slipping into normal time, as a wave of wetness washed over his eyes.

“No matter how good you are, getting hit in the face, at least when it causes damage, is going to rock your focus. Hands up. You should be guarding. This isn’t a match where you can dodge everything.”



Slowly, Lodestar was getting a feel for this team. Agent Quantum had the right makings for a leader, but he could be a bit too set on his path to change when needed. Tachyonic was stuck in the classic super-speed trap—he'd tried to learn to do everything faster, rather than better. Plasmodia possessed easily the most stopping power but was kept on the backlines due to her supposed vulnerability, never mind the fact that she had plenty of defensive options. As for Presto, he might actually have the sharpest mind of the four. Pity he seemed intent on concealing and misusing that potential.

Sure enough, Tachyonic proved her theory by racing in once more. He was going faster this time, because of course he was. That was the Professor Quantum method for overcoming a hurdle: stronger, faster, tougher, better. Dominate, win—all that idiot crap Lodestar had been forced to dig out by the root when starting the Alliance of Heroic Champions. Had Tachyonic taken a moment to truly consider the situation, he'd have remembered that Lodestar was only ever matching *his* speed. Going faster changed nothing. This wasn't a fight that could be won by adding more power.

More punches, though these were at least a tad tighter than before. Lodestar blocked the first two swings, feinted a third jab that Tachyonic fell for, and came around with a right hook to his jaw. She tried to hold back; however, moving at those speeds made it difficult to entirely pull the blow. She still sent Tachyonic stumbling back onto his butt.

With his landing, their time in the land of super-speed came to an end. Lodestar decided to reengage with the other recovering members of the team. Agent Quantum was mostly to his feet, but she could still hear Presto whistling through the air above them. Plasmodia would fire when given a chance; however, by this point, she'd yet to land a single shot. Hopefully, she'd realize that with Tachyonic's speed in play, Lodestar could dodge most ranged attacks and come in closer. She'd love to see what Plasmodia could do when truly pushed. Unfortunately, knowing the training they'd gotten, Lodestar highly doubted the young woman would break formation. Professor Quantum drilled those lessons in especially hard.

As Agent Quantum looked her over, she wondered if he was going to step up. This plan wasn't working, not unless they had a secret reveal prepared for the last moment. There was still time to change things, to try something new, but that would demand throwing away their current tactics. It was a hard call to make for any leader: stick with what they knew, even though it was failing, versus rolling the dice on an untested strategy. With a

team this developed, there would be other tactics they could shift to, ones they'd no doubt drilled and polished as much as their current formation. The question was, would any of them work against an opponent as strong as their own team, and could Agent Quantum figure out which?

"Plasmodia, switch to rapid shots. Let's keep her dancing. Presto, pick a number between one and a hundred. Count to that, then make your jump. She can't predict your timing if it's randomized. Tachyonic, switch to support. Use that speed as a surprise. Don't let her see you coming. I'll take her on in melee."

"That a fact?" Lodestar liked that he'd changed things up; however, he'd only shifted the variables, rather than the strategy as a whole. While it could still work, she wasn't holding her breath on that making the difference.

In response, Agent Quantum raised his own fists. "Since you gave Tachyonic a real sparring session, care to teach it to someone who has been more thoroughly trained in hand-to-hand combat?"

"Nope." Lodestar dashed over, sweeping Agent Quantum's legs and knocking him in the stomach on his way down. "The point of that lesson wasn't that he needs a boxing tutor. It's that you all have weaknesses. Knowing what they are allows you to plan around them. Ignoring them leaves opponents an opening to exploit."

Although she could see Tachyonic preparing for another charge and Plasmodia building up energy to shoot once more, in her heart Lodestar knew this test had likely reached its conclusion. Much as she'd been hoping they'd think on their feet, it appeared they were continuing on with trying the same thing, only more powerful. It was an issue she'd expected when taking on Professor Quantum's team, and one she dearly hoped could be trained out of them.

The other way that lesson sank in wasn't pretty. It came in the field, when a team fought someone truly beyond their abilities, and usually ended in several funerals. Lodestar would do all she could to educate this group before that day came.

In the moment, that lesson probably required leaving them publicly defeated. A blow to the ego was far, *far* better than what awaited them if they didn't learn their lessons during training—even if it meant one more set of superheroes that resented her. She could already see the frustration in their eyes catalyzing into anger, know they were thinking it wasn't fair, this

gulf of power between them. They were right, but it didn't change the fact that they'd eventually fight a stronger opponent.

She could bear their resentment, their distance, if it meant they'd be able to survive. One more burden added to the countless on her shoulders. This one, at least, she'd been prepared for since the evaluation started. It was how these things always turned out, sooner or later. Admiration turned to jealousy, annoyance, or frustration as attempt after attempt to surpass her power failed.

Standing at the top meant standing alone.

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## Chapter 50

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The worryingly thin woman with skin the color of an old lime moved quietly through the front door, causing a large bell overhead to tinkle loudly. Inside the unremarkable door was a wood-paneled hallway leading deeper into the well-aged building. From down the expanse, music drifted along. Nothing remotely modern, this had a peppy, bouncy rhythm. One might have used the word jaunty, even if it weren't normally within their vocabulary.

For Lozora, the sound conjured dim memories of her time in the lab. One of the scientists used to leave a television on for her brood at night, believing it would better socialize them with humans. That one had favored older works, some dating back to the days before color. This wasn't a tune she could particularly recall, it was merely in the style of those programs. Lozora was never sure if that scientist was eaten during the escape, or if they'd been out on the fateful day. As the lone survivor, there was no way to ask the others which humans they'd torn apart in the dash to freedom.

At the end of the hall, there was a single turn. Down a bit further, another door waited. This one hosted a huge glass pane in the center, marking the business as "Vaudeville and Toon: Destructive Indestructibles" in elaborate gold lettering. She was in the right place, moving silently along the weathered floor. No need to turn the knob, she realized, since the door was cracked. That explained how the music was traveling so well.

Pushing her way inside, Lozora found herself looking directly at a desk with a woman behind it. A very distinctive woman, at that: pants held aloft

by suspenders, starched shirt, bow tie, a flat-topped straw hat, and a plainly plastic mustache that came to absurdly curly points at each end.

The moment she saw Lozora enter, the curiously dressed woman sprang to her feet, tipping the straw hat and knocking a bottle of ink Lozora hadn't seen seconds prior onto the floor. It spread across the wood in a dark, oozing puddle, yet the woman paid the spill not the slightest of mind.

"Good afternoon! Welcome to Vaudeville and Toon, Independent Disaster Contracting. As you might have guessed, I'm Vaudeville, in the flesh. What can I do for you today?"

"My employer is interested in your services." She wasn't entirely sure what to make of Vaudeville, having only ever known the woman by reputation. She didn't seem like much outside of an oddball, but that meant nothing. According to reports, she and Toon were among the highest-ranked metas in existence for survivability. The latter had supposedly even survived a scuffle with Fornax. That was the sort of power it was useful to have around.

"Of course, you did walk into our office. Services must be in demand, so tell me the skinny. Boss have a competing bar we need to go for a dance at? Maybe a business we should patronize? Tell us where you need the chaos, and that's where we'll be." She paused, looking Lozora over more carefully. "With some exceptions, by matter of policy."

Best to start with the caveats. Lozora might save herself some time. "What sorts of exceptions?"

"The expected sort. Ya see, Toon and I occupy a niche in the laws and protections around meta-humans. We exert influence on the world around us simply by existing in it. We cause chaos and trouble no matter where we go. The reason that's legal is because we can't control it, and jailing us for effects outside our control crosses several legal lines. That said, we're also not stooges. Laws can change, ya know. It's why we avoid anything related to or around the Alliance of Heroic Champions. Not looking to pick a fight with people who can put the kibosh on our business."

About what Lozora had expected. It was standard practice among those who'd been around long enough to build a reputation in the first place. Steering clear of the capes was just good sense, which was what made her employer's aspirations all the rarer. Not many were left who'd challenge the AHC directly. Luckily, he'd also found places for assets that were technically unconnected from what the capes would be dealing with.

“That won’t be an issue,” Lozora replied.

“Tickled as a hog in hosiery to hear it.” Another look, this one more probing. “I’ll ask your forgiveness for the uncouth addition, but given your overall deadly demeanor, feels prudent to mention we also don’t tango with the other side of that equation. Vaudeville and Toon are strictly a civilian service. We avoid the major leagues.”

Here, unfortunately, they had an issue. From a door on the left, annoyed ranting could be heard. Seconds later, it could also be seen, as actual scribbles and blurred-out symbols manifested in the air. That was the only warning before the door slammed open and a new man ambled through.

He had a strange movement to him, a constant bounce, like he was never truly still. His intense expression was a sharp contrast to the bright, cheerful hues he was clad in, and the coifed bobbing hair swaying atop his skull. It was hard to place this person’s age. His skin was off in texture, somehow just... not right, but it lacked any signs of aging. Older than a teen, younger than what most would consider a true adult, the man was a shifting tapestry as he took long, unusual steps through the room.

“Your partner agrees with that, or does he make his own choices?”

“Toon isn’t one to get bogged down in details. He prefers the fun,” Vaudeville replied.

“He’s also out of beer. Turned into milk again.” From a small mini-fridge, Toon produced a brown bottle, then very carefully eased the door shut.

As soon as it clicked, a stack of books fell from literally nowhere, smacking Vaudeville in the cranium one after another. With every blow, she teetered more and more off-balance, until the last one sent her to the ground. Then, moments later, Vaudeville was back up as if nothing had happened. That was the thing about these two: easy to hit, near impossible to hurt.

Looking mildly embarrassed by the bookslide, Toon managed a repentant expression, albeit not well. This was a bit too commonplace for the pair to feel bad about. “Sorry, didn’t mean to do that in front of a client.”

“That’s quite all right, Toon,” Vaudeville assured him. “Our guest was leaving anyway, seeing as she’s clearly here recruiting for some sort of larger caper, and we don’t fit in. Besides, she just tried to play us against

each other. I'm not fond of working with those who can't respect the bond between partners."

While Lozora was technically here diplomatically, she still felt her spine tense. Perhaps this woman didn't quite realize who she was talking to. Lozora was no mere lackey to be drummed out when someone else's patience wore thin. Tapping her hands against the arms of the chair, Lozora began to rise.

"Oh goody and gumption. Toon, looks like you might get to have some fun today after all."

Toon looked from Lozora to Vaudeville, then dropped the beer into a wastebasket, where it somehow made a sound like a ringside bell. Putting his right thumb to his mouth, Toon began to blow. As he did, his entire fist swelled in size to absurd, comical proportions. A literal gleam twinkled in both of his now wide eyes, the first signs of genuine excitement he'd shown, all pointed directly at Lozora.

"Step right on up, my bold challenger. I promise, you ain't never had a fight like me."



Helen took her time putting Penelope to bed. They sang songs, had a long tub time, and even did rereads of some favorite stories. It felt good to be here—human, and home. She reveled in being around someone who had little care for Lodestar, powers, superheroes, any of it. To Penelope, Helen would be Mom above all other titles, and after days like this, she needed that. As all children do, however, Penelope eventually gave in to slumber.

Part of her—no, much more than a part—wanted to call Ivan. He understood what it meant to be at the top. The solitude, the distance, the pressure. But it wasn't fair of her to add to his burdens. He was already carrying enough. She was the Lodestar; she could haul her own mental crap around. Setting her resolve, Helen wandered into the kitchen and poured a glass of wine.

The last drops were nearly fallen when her phone chirped. She knew the sound—not many people had their own custom tones, but there were those who warranted the distinction. Yanking it out, she prepared for Ivan to tell

her something about the Starscouts, or perhaps offer some insight into Tori's kidnapping.

*Are you free?*

Well... that was unexpected. Blunt, which did fit Ivan, though he tended to err on the side of formality, at least since taking on his civilian role. Her thumb wavered, unsure of what to write back. Yes, she was free. Yes, she wanted to see him, to share the events of her day. That was the trouble. She liked Ivan, liked being around him. When she'd been living as just Helen, that was one thing. Now, the issue was more complicated. In the end, Helen decided that since there was a chance this could be related to official business, she had a duty to investigate.

Even Lodestar was allowed a small bit of self-delusion.

*For the moment. Something up?*

She didn't even have time to put the phone down before his reply came.

*In person.*

Damn. If he couldn't talk about it even over their secured lines, then this was indeed serious. All thoughts of relaxation and light flirting bolted from Helen's mind as she tried to predict what threat they might be facing.

*Come over and read me in.*

Again, she didn't set the phone down in time. Another chirp, another message. Reading it twice, Helen lifted an eyebrow and walked through the house to her back door. Popping it open, she stepped onto her porch to find Ivan already sitting there, staring out at the night sky. There was something in his expression, a pain she'd seen prior incarnations of, though never to this degree. A joke about personal property faded on her tongue. This was no laughing matter.

"Ivan, what's wrong?"

She expected him to need some time, but that made little sense. Ivan had come to her to talk. He wasn't going to hold back when the chance finally arrived.

"Rick has started to remember the beach. Enough that he asked about it, and I told him the truth of that day. He still hasn't asked the big questions yet, but it's only a matter of time." Lowering his gaze, Ivan pressed his hands against his forehead. "My son is going to see me as a monster, and I don't know how to stop it. Or even if I *should* stop it. He has a right to know my history; the people with grudges certainly will."



Taking her time, Helen went into the house, scooping up a pair of old quilts. Stepping back out, she hunkered down in the chair next to Ivan, handing over the blanket. “Summer is ending. The nights are starting to chill. Remember, have to look human.”

While Ivan worked out which part of the quilt was the top, Helen continued. “I don’t know what to say about the Rick stuff. That bites the big one? No, bad call, forget that. It just... sucks, Ivan, and I wish I could say something to make it better. Except, the truth is, this was always a hurdle you two had to climb. Eventually, our kids will find out we’re more than just their parents. Some have an easier adjustment to make than others, but Rick is smart. He’ll be able to see the bigger picture. Whether or not he can make peace with it... that’s up to him to decide.”

“Sadly, I am all too aware.” Ivan had finally managed to get the blanket oriented appropriately, letting it sit at his waist like an elderly man at a chessboard. For a moment, Helen tried to imagine old Ivan. It didn’t work. He, like her, was largely unchanging, save only for when he made the *big* changes. She couldn’t imagine Ivan living to an old age any more than herself. Superheroes and villains alike, they were both fated to go out with their masks on.

“The only upside is I can offer comfort on one level: you don’t need to worry about Rick or Beth being targets. Not from the AHC, and not from anyone within punching distance of me. We don’t ever talk about how much you’ve done for me and Penelope—”

Ivan interrupted her. “I was paying back—”

“Cut the crap,” Helen interrupted right back. “Paying me back for helping you get the freedom you’d earned doesn’t entail a tenth of what you’ve done over the years. From the very start, you were the one who gave me the downtime to have her, and since then, you’ve been a constant help, one I probably leaned on too much during the rough times.”

It was always surprising when Ivan could somehow manage to look even *more* serious than he normally did, yet as he stared Helen down, she was nearly captured by the gravity in his gaze. “Trifles and pittance. *Everything* I love, I have in my life because of your help. There is no way to repay that debt, though I owe you a lifetime of effort in trying.”

“Guess what, that feeling flows both ways.” Finally fiddling with her own blanket, Helen snapped it out in a single movement, letting it settle naturally over her chair and body. “After all you’ve done for Penelope, I

owe at least that level of care to your kids. So whatever else you might be scared of in all of this, try not to worry about their safety. I'm not perfect, nor infallible, but so long as the power is mine to wield, your kids will always have Lodestar in their corner."

It would have shocked most people, to see Ivan relax at those words, even slightly. He was not a man of casual ease, nor one prone to trusting. But he knew more than most of the world; he'd seen how much power Lodestar could truly wield, when the need arose. For the moment, Ivan allowed himself a minute measure of peace. Likely the very thing he'd come here hoping to find.

"Much as my pride wants to decline the gesture, for the sake of my children, I thank you sincerely." Ivan lowered his head, almost managing a bow despite their seated positions. "And I'm sorry for interrupting your evening so abruptly."

"Given the situation, I get it. Honestly, I'm sort of glad you showed up. My day was a pain, as well. It's nice to sit with an old friend."

An old friend, an old enemy, an old rival, an old asset, even an old partner for the occasional shared adversary. After all these years, there were few roles they hadn't filled for the other at some point along the way. Only a few were left purposefully, willfully, untouched—no matter how much either of them might wish to be sharing a single quilt.

"Anything interesting? I could use a distraction."

This question, thankfully, Helen had an easy response to. "I got shot in the face by a bunch of birds."

A sincere, contemplative look fell over Ivan's face. "Do you mean you were hit by a large amount of birds, or a flock of them banded together to actually shoot some sort of tiny guns at you?"

There was no particular reason why that got her, but seeing the man once known as Fornax ask such a question with a straight face sent Helen into convulsions of laughter that took a full minute to fade.

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## Chapter 51

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Sunday evening arrived too soon for Tori, who'd spent nearly every spare second since her meeting with Doctor Mechanical down in the lab, hard at work. She needed to get a fully functioning prototype built so she'd have actual specs. Until they knew the exact size and shape, she couldn't very well tap Beverly to start much of the design work. It had been one thing when this was all an idea, just some fun notion to sink her energy into rather than dwelling on everything that had happened. Having Indigo Technologies provisionally on board changed things. Now, it had the potential to be real, and Tori was determined not to let the chance slip away.

When Beverly finally dragged her out of the lab, it was a blessing. She'd been at it for a long time without any breaks and was starting to slow down mentally. Changing gears would give her brain time to rest. It wasn't as if game night with the New Science Sentries would demand the same level of intense focus.

After a shower and a few cups of coffee, Tori was more or less as functional as she got outside of things that interested her. She expected to coast her way through the evening in a subdued manner, letting the more boisterous members of their social circle pick up the slack.

Once the knock on their door came, however, the flaw in that plan became apparent. It was a weary foursome that arrived at their door. None looked especially well rested, and their overall energy was somewhere on Tori's level, which was worrying. The sole member putting up the appearance of pep was Austin, who greeted Chloe cheerfully when she let them in.

“Good evening, and thank you again for having us. We brought some playing cards, wine, and a batch of homemade cookies for dessert.”

“Oh, perfect! We just ordered pizza for dinner. I didn’t know everyone’s preferences well enough to cook.” Chloe accepted the cookies from Austin while Tori ambled over to help with the wine. Beverly was still getting ready, or maybe wanted to make an entrance. Tori never understood the rules of the fashionable.

Taking both wine bottles from Kyle, she noticed he was especially subdued, even by the group’s current standards. The easier play would be to let it go unsaid, leave the issue alone since it was almost certainly cape-related. Except, she was supposed to be friendly, and this was way too obvious to pretend it wasn’t there. Ultimately, Tori opted to split the difference. She’d give Kyle a window; if he didn’t use it, that was on him.

“Come help me uncork these bad boys. With this many people, we’ll go through both fast.” Leading Kyle over to the kitchen, leaving the other three chatting with Chloe at the entrance, she walked him to the junk drawer and popped out a bottle opener. “Want to talk about it?”

“Huh?” He hadn’t been braced for that. The question appeared to be the first thing that had jarred him into paying attention. “Sorry, what?”

“I’m asking if you want to talk about whatever dark cloud is hanging over all your heads. ’Cause if so, do it now. I’m not interrupting a winning streak because you get a case of feelings.” A little harsher than she’d intended, Tori took a breath and dialed it back. “I mean, something is plainly up. You don’t want to talk about it, your call. Just making an offer to listen while we wait for Beverly.”

The slight pop behind her was all the warning Tori needed. Without turning, she held out a glass of poured wine slightly to her rear, where Ike accepted it as he walked around to Kyle’s side. “He’s miffed because we had an evaluation at the Alliance of Heroic Champions, and our team wasn’t able to overcome the challenge presented. Which is the polite way of saying we got our asses kicked.”

“Not... we didn’t do that badly. We just didn’t succeed at the task assigned, despite coming close a few times,” Kyle corrected.

“Coming close? I never even got a hand on that rock. Austin came nearest, and that was right before the time limit. We might have fought until the end, but we were far from success.”

The conversation only seemed to be riling Kyle up, which was admittedly better than the morose version. Tori thrust a glass of wine over. It wouldn't be able to affect someone with his metabolism, but the routine act of drinking sometimes helped to calm people down. "Were you up against some sort of monster, or giant murdering robot?"

"What?" Kyle asked, swinging his head around. "Of course not. Who would test their new members with that kind of opponent?"

Clearly *someone* had never been through villain training. Tori enjoyed a whole three seconds of feeling superior about the hurdles she'd cleared—right up until Kyle named their actual adversary.

"We had to test ourselves against Lodestar."

Setting the wine down, Tori went to the fridge and pulled out a bottle of beer. She'd never been much of a wine fan, and there was no reason to change that tonight. Popping the top, Tori clapped Kyle on the back lightly. "I'm pretty sure you don't have to feel bad about losing to the person famous for being unbeatable. She's the fucking Lodestar. What else did you expect? Who's going to come out on top against her?"

"Cyber Geek's team, for one." Ellie had wandered over, leaving Austin and Chloe still catching up by the door. The man was dedicated to his polite small talk, Tori had to give him that. Ellie drew more attention, though, as she poured herself a very full glass of wine. "We didn't have to fight her, *per se*. We had to take something she was guarding. And since she matched her power with whoever she was fighting, the stronger you are, the harder your challenge. So at least we can take comfort in how weak that squad must be."

Ellie lifted her glass, and Ike clinked. Only Kyle resisted the urge to join, showing unexpectedly good judgment, given his track record.

"Look, I'm sure there's all sorts of rivalries and pissing matches going on in the AHC, but let's lay one thing out right here and now: Cyber Geek is a friend of mine. We worked together, we fought together when our office was attacked, and he saved a whole nightclub full of people, me included, when Nexus let a monster loose on the dance floor. You've got beef, fine. Keep it between yourselves. But that's going to be the last time you shit-talk my friend in my presence. Anyone got an issue with that?"

Ellie looked stunned, and even Ike appeared momentarily taken aback. Kyle, however, recovered for his team, showing off that speedy thinking for a change. "Apologies, Tori. It was inappropriate. We shouldn't talk about a

fellow superhero that way, and we certainly don't have room to belittle the strength of a team that did better than us. It won't happen again, though I do hope this policy flows both ways."

"I guess it would, but he's never really mentioned your team." Only after she said the words did Tori realize how they might be perceived. That was the cost of knowing tech better than people, stumbling into errors that a more socially adept person could avoid.

"Oh? Then what is it you *do* talk about?" For once, she was glad to have Ike around. His ridiculous innuendo was exactly the pivot she needed from that last statement.

"Spreadsheets, combat tactics, our eventual inevitable battle to the death. The usual former office drone stuff." Talking about it made Tori realize she actually hadn't had more than a phone call or a brief chat with Donald in some while. She should reach out, make sure he was holding up okay. If this was how the New Science Sentries were faring, it had to be a rough time as a recent rookie.

Heels clicking along wood signified Beverly's arrival, and Tori felt her head turn with everyone else's even though she knew who was coming. That was Beverly's knack; she could draw the attention of a room before even setting a foot inside. Once she actually arrived, Tori nearly coughed on a sip of beer. She was accustomed to Beverly, her roommate and friend, the one who always looked put together, but in a functional, office-appropriate manner. Tonight she hadn't changed much, yet the effect was potent. A touch more makeup here, a slightly different cut to her blouse there, and suddenly Tori realized why Beverly could survive by simply writing about fashion. The woman knew her stuff to a terrifying degree.

What was more interesting was the enhanced appearance itself. Obviously, she hadn't put in the effort for Tori or Chloe, which narrowed it down to the New Science Sentries. One glance at Austin's near slack-jawed face told her which of the group was having the strongest reaction, and to Tori's surprise, she caught Beverly clocking Austin's face, too. First mystery solved easily enough; the second was more troublesome, unfortunately. Was Beverly actually making an effort, or just screwing with Austin for fun? She'd never been the cruel sort—then again, Beverly didn't hate many people the way she hated Professor Quantum. It was hard to imagine her seriously flirting with his successor. Perhaps she was using her wiles to win him over, hoping to gain useful information about the AHC?

Tori shook off the curiosity, all too aware she lacked the skills to crack this puzzle. The easier method was just to get through the night, then ask Beverly later. That was the perk of being outside the courtship dance; she wasn't bound by any of the unspoken rules.

"My goodness, where did you get that top?" Ellie rushed over before Austin had recovered enough to speak. "I love it! I've been hunting all over Ridge City for wardrobe updates, mostly to no luck."

"You have to know the good spots, plus a little tailoring. Nothing comes perfect off the rack," Beverly explained. "Next time you have a day off, I can take you around to some favorites. Maybe with your help, I can drag these two along."

Finally ambling over from the door, Chloe piped up. "Hey, I went with you once. I just rarely get full days off. We don't all do freelance or get corporate hours."

"Yes, you at least have an excuse." Beverly narrowed her eyes at Tori, who met the glare with a casual shrug.

"My excuse is that I don't want to."

That deepened Beverly's stare, but had no effect on Ellie's enthusiasm. "That's all right. I'd be happy just for the guidance and company."

It was an interesting move. From what Tori could tell, Beverly had decided to embrace the friendship angle to a greater degree than herself. Then again, she'd asked Kyle what was wrong, so that was significant effort on her part. Maybe they were still playing the same strategy after all; she was just noticing the difference in how effective each were.

"I'll try to tag along if the timing works out. I've got some new looks in mind I want to get outfits for." Chloe was excited as well, and Tori wondered how many times she'd be walking in on gorgeous strangers as Chloe played with the newly discovered aspect of her powers.

While those three grouped up, Austin at last found his feet and wandered into the heart of the apartment. Taking a small glass and filling it with water, he paused next to Tori. "I thought you might like to know, your friend fought very well. His team not only passed the evaluation, they did so while putting on a fine show."

"Glad to hear it. So, you're not jealous?" Tori asked.

"Oh, I am incredibly envious," Austin corrected. "Also a bit resentful, if we're being honest. It's hard not to feel like this is all wrong. We're fighting the way we were trained by one of history's greatest superheroes and are

being told we're wrong at nearly every turn. Meanwhile, the team closely associated with a traitor keeps finding success and acclaim. I understand they weren't part of Apollo's scheme, but I hope you can see why that would be frustrating for my people. They really are doing the best they can every time. That's why it hurts so much to keep feeling like failures."

Years ago, months ago, she'd have tossed those words aside, assuming them to be pure fiction. The trouble was, being around the capes this much had shown Tori a truth she couldn't fully ignore: some of them were sincere. Not all, probably not even most, but a few were doing the job because they truly wanted to make the world better, safer, for the normal people who lived in it. She'd seen an everyday programmer lay down his life for others multiple times, simply because he had enough strength to try. Hell, she'd looked into the eyes of Lodestar and seen only true concern behind them. Tori didn't know Austin or Agent Quantum well enough to have a clue if he was in that club or not, but she had a hunch. Enough to throw him a line. Whether he took it or not would determine how much of his demeanor was playing the part versus his true ambitions.

"I mean, there's a solution here, if you're serious. You really want to get better at this job, to see what the differences in your tactics are? Go ask Cyber Geek if you can tag along with his team for a few nights."

While the idea wasn't rejected immediately, Austin's face creased in visible concern. "There's merit to that idea, granted, but I'm afraid it might be too late. Our teams haven't gotten off to the greatest start; I fear such a request from me would seem like teasing, at best, or setting them up for some sort of trick, at worst."

Beverly and Chloe had gotten out the stack of board games and were beginning the discussion. Seeing several strategy options that would have them playing for half the night in the mix, Tori realized she needed to weigh in on this choice, and soon. Hitting the fridge for one more beer, she paused briefly by Austin's side.

"Convince Cyber Geek you're coming to him sincerely, and he'll agree to the pairing, bad blood or not. He cares more about the people you're protecting than the politics of the AHC. Make him believe you want to be better capes and he won't be able to turn you away."

Austin nodded. "Thank you. I'll think on that." From the way his eyes kept swinging back over to Beverly's side of the room, Tori doubted he'd get much critical contemplation accomplished that evening. She'd done her



part, though, so with a clear conscience, she attacked the group choosing the night's diversion.

“Chloe, put that ten-hour strategy game down, and no one gets hurt!”

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## Chapter 52

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Monday morning brought with it an unexpected message. It wasn't as though Tori hadn't kept in contact with Lance and Warren—Pest Control and Glyph, as they were known in the guild. They'd touched base during the guild's downtime, making sure all the rookies were laying low and staying safe. They'd both fallen silent in recent weeks; the new guild opening marked the chance to start working again, and no doubt the pair were busy with their own lives.

That's what made Lance's unexpected invitation to a meeting so out of the blue. The implication was clear, obviously. Some kind of guild business. Maybe Lance needed tech consulting, wanted air surveillance to monitor a location, or he was looking for backup on a job. The wide range of possibilities poked at Tori's curiosity. Besides, there was also the inevitable truth that she needed money, and if it was a job, guild work paid extremely well.

Designing and building a new product line was going to be expensive. She could foist the funding onto Indigo, except there was no way to do that without also cutting them in on a greater share of the profits. While Tori had made peace with the need for a corporate alliance, that didn't mean she wanted to hand over any more power or leverage than necessary. As much as possible, she would be the driving force of her creations. She wasn't quite sure that would be enough to motivate her to brave another museum heist, but it was worth taking the meeting. There was always the option to say no, if the offer didn't sound like her scene.

A crisp knock on her bedroom door came a few moments before Beverly's voice. "Saw some photographers creeping along the west side of the building, and Chloe is already getting ready for work. You might want to take the back door today."

It took all of Tori's control not to let out a groan that was audible from the street. Stupid photographers still hanging around. She wanted to be done with them, except the attention was still necessary for her long-term plans. Besides, it wasn't like she had a way to get rid of them. None that wouldn't involve guild tactics, anyway.

Beverly hit the door once again, softer this time. "You get a text from Lance?"

"Sure did. Meeting tonight?"

"That's the one," Beverly's voice confirmed. "Up for it?"

Tori's mind flashed to her Hephaestus suit, sitting down in the lab. She hadn't gotten to take it out for more than a few hours at the guild's relaunch, a pitiful amount of field-testing time. Even aside from that, part of her missed the feel of her tech encompassing her entirely. Tori enjoyed being Hephaestus, perhaps more than she let herself realize initially. If she wanted to suit up again, the guild was where she'd find her best opportunities.

Not to mention, she was sick of playing helpless. Between the car thrown at her head and the kidnapping, Tori had been affecting the role of mundane civilian too much for her liking. It was time to be powerful again. It was time to be Hephaestus.

"Why not? Could be fun."



It had been a hell of a weekend. Passing the evaluation was a high point, obviously, but the celebration with his team that followed had been a darn good time as well. Sans costumes, they'd gone out to a nice dinner in celebration, then followed things up with a downright horrific session of karaoke, in which they learned Irene was a shockingly talented soprano and Lucy could clear half a room with the first ten notes of a song. Ren always stuck to something country, low and simple. He'd gotten much better at speaking with his altered tongue since the change, but he still avoided anything that demanded rapid linguistic skills. As for Donald, he'd picked

an old favorite that was more talk-singing than actual music, but it was on the list, so he'd considered it fair game.

One unexpected cherry had come Sunday night: a text from Tori about wanting to grab lunch and catch up soon. After weeks of working to be better at his job, and an objective evaluation that said his team was doing well, Donald found he could easily justify taking some time off to see her. Important as being a superhero was, it couldn't make up the entirety of his life. That wasn't healthy for any profession, not even capes.

The text was still on his mind as he walked down the AHC's halls Monday morning. With breakfast at his back, Donald planned to do some serious gaming today. The evaluation had reminded him of a tool Cyber Geek was going to eventually need: flight. Suit thrusters were fine for short distances, but sooner or later, they'd face an airborne opponent. When that day arrived, he was the only team member with the versatility to meet them in the sky. It was just a matter of seeing which flight systems translated well into the real world, and which left him spinning out.

He was so lost in thought about zipping through the sky that Donald almost didn't hear the voice calling for him until it was practically on his heels. In his defense, though, he only tended to think of himself as "Cyber Geek" while in costume.

Turning, he found Agent Quantum, sans the usual tagalongs, approaching. Not the best surprise possible, but at least Agent Quantum always conducted himself like a professional.

"Sorry, didn't mean to run you down," Agent Quantum said once he finally arrived. "But I saw you leaving the cafeteria and thought it might be serendipity. I wanted to speak with you, in private, when you have a moment."

Initially, Donald was torn. The New Science Sentries hadn't exactly gone out of their way to get on his team's good side. If anything, they'd been downright antagonistic. With a long day of work ahead, a very real part of Donald wanted to politely brush him off, sticking to the schedule that he'd planned. That inclination only lasted the micro-seconds necessary to remember where, precisely, he was standing.

They were in the hall of the Alliance of Heroic Champions, not some shitty office condo in downtown. This wasn't a corporate cog job where what they did had little to no effect on the world. Whatever else might be

going on, they were both superheroes, and if Agent Quantum was willing to extend an olive branch, then Cyber Geek should at least hear him out.

“We’re not far from my room, if you want to follow me. I’ve got some free time until my next task.”

A tension that was extremely easy to miss left Agent Quantum’s shoulders as he nodded, a wary smile on his face. Together, they started down the hall once more, though this time walking together, rather than one trailing the other.



Ivan was waiting at his desk when Tori came in. He knew she’d be heading over, because he was the one who’d scheduled a meeting to start their week. As much as Ivan wanted to put the weekend out of his head, he couldn’t, and not just because the look on Rick’s face haunted him constantly. There were other implications to that discussion, ones that his former apprentice needed to know. The odds of the situation coming into play were minimal, but one didn’t work in a field of the miraculous without learning to plan for the impossible, to say nothing of the unlikely.

She was surprisingly prompt, arriving a full three minutes before they were due to start. As Tori walked in with a mug of coffee in hand, Ivan gave a short, pointed look at the door. Kicking it with her foot mid-stroll, Tori knocked it closed, after which Ivan hit unseen buttons hidden somewhere on the desk. One day, she’d really love to tear into these walls and see how much obfuscating tech Wade had woven through the building.

“What’s up? This about Lance’s text this morning?”

That was news to Ivan, so he shook his head. “Something more personal.” He waited while she got comfortable in her seat. No, that wasn’t quite right. Ivan wasn’t necessarily waiting so much as he was unsure of how to proceed. This was a big topic to bite off, especially given the potential ramifications. Ultimately, Ivan decided to push through bluntly. If nothing else, he and Tori both appreciated someone cutting to the heart of a matter.

“This weekend, Rick began to ask me questions about my past. He’s figured out that my old stories don’t line up, and as of now, knows that I am

both a meta-human and a murderer, though my true identity has yet to be revealed.”

A parade of expressions ran across Tori’s face as she struggled to find fitting words to offer. In the end, she settled on glum. “That really blows.” Not especially eloquent, but sincere all the same.

“It very much does,” Ivan agreed. “However, that alone would be my burden to bear. The larger issue is that in Rick’s digging, he uncovered our purported genealogical connection. Given that it conflicted with the story he knew of my heritage, the detail stuck out to him. While I’ve tried hard to impart upon him that this is my secret, and stays between us, he is a sixteen-year-old, with all the rash decision-making that comes with the age. Worse, he’s got his mother’s smarts, meaning he might actually be effective at digging where he shouldn’t. There is a chance he’ll reach out to you, given what he’s grappling with and the connection he now knows we share.”

This time, Tori’s face was more guarded. She nodded along in understanding, giving away little more than that. “I get it. He found a rabbit hole, poked his head in, and is trying to figure out if he wants to see how far down it really goes. Since I’m the only person he knows who isn’t a parent that’s connected, there’s a chance he’ll try to approach me for more information.”

A pause as something familiar peered out from behind Tori’s guard. Fear. Of course fear. Always fear. In this case, Ivan certainly couldn’t hold it against her. This was fear he’d specifically imparted. He had no one to blame but himself.

“Given the protectiveness you feel toward your kids, I’m not looking to cross any lines here. If you want me to tell him to hit the bricks, I will. If you want me to try to soften the edges of what he’s going to learn, I’ll do my best, but let’s be honest, I might do more harm than good there. Point is, I’m following your lead.”

“I appreciate that.” Ivan looked down at his desk, where several pictures of his children through the years were featured. His eyes went to the youngest picture of Rick, still so small, riding on his father’s shoulders without a care in the world. For all the tremendous power Ivan could tap into, he’d have happily cast it aside to live in that day, that moment, once more. Sadly, not even Fornax could fight the forward march of time. Rick was no longer a little boy he could easily carry around. He was less than two years from the age Ivan had been when he became Fornax. In no time,

Rick would be his own man, and when that day came, he was better served by being as informed as possible.

Finally turning from his photos, Ivan met Tori's uncertain gaze. "Tell him anything he wants to know, assuming you're comfortable sharing. The only exceptions are the guild, and my true identity. The first for obvious reasons, the second because I feel I should be the one to handle that reveal. It will be... difficult."

"If he asks me if I've ever seen you kill?"

"You'd be perfectly in your rights to tell him that, yes, you have. Several people," Ivan said. "At this point, Rick doesn't trust much of what his mother or I say, and not without some reason. I'd rather him have an information source he believes than spare him truths he seems bound to eventually uncover. All of that is assuming he approaches you, which may very well not happen. I simply didn't want you to be caught unaware."

Tori took a long sip from her coffee mug, mulling the words over. "I appreciate the heads up, and I'll give some thought to how much I want to divulge if he does make a move."

"I think that's the best strategy, for the moment." Ivan was about to dismiss her, except a rogue glance to his calendar reminded him that there was one more matter of business to attend. "Before you go, remember that this week's Starscout meeting is bumped to tomorrow due to a district field trip. Kids should still be tuckered even when they get back, so we'll be putting the extra time to use. Got to prepare for the End of Summer Shindig next week, meaning there's always work to do."

"Almost forgot about those." To Ivan's surprise, Tori actually appeared happy about the change. "Sounds nice, a little normalcy after weeks of the insane. Plus, bonus, I actually got to meet Lodestar during the kidnapping. That should make a fun story for the kids, right?"

In his mind's eye, Ivan could already imagine the looks Helen would be shooting as Tori regaled the kids with tales of meeting their organization's founder. Annoying as they would be, he could just as easily imagine the wide-eyed joy of the children getting to hear that tale, Beth included. In the end, Starscouts was about the kids, and Tori was right. They would absolutely eat that story up.

"A fine idea. But word to the wise: bring throat lozenges. Giving a tale like that to children their age, you're going to find yourself with quite a few requests for encores."

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## Chapter 53

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“You want to team up?” Donald had the screen on his TV glowing, and the special receiver booted up. It connected to the computer system wired into his body, loading a screen with dozens of games, all of which were constantly running in the background. Professor Quantum might not be as personable as Donald expected, but the tech he built absolutely lived up to the reputation. Comparing this to the wrist unit he’d been wielding initially was night and day.

“I wish I was asking for a team-up,” Agent Quantum replied. “That would be a much easier sell to my people. But there’s no sense in doing this unless we tackle it properly, which means accepting the truth. I don’t want to team up. I want you to let us shadow you for a few nights. It’s become increasingly clear that our training didn’t prepare us as well as we expected for this job. We’re doing the new drills, listening to the response tactics, it’s just not clicking. My hope is that watching another team up close will show us where it is we’re falling short. It’s the best way to improve.”

Making a snap decision, Donald chose a two-player game, grabbing a spare controller from the charging dock by the television. He tossed it into Agent Quantum’s hands, who stared at the device with a scrunched-up expression that looked quite out of place on his handsome face. “Might as well train while we talk. I’m leveling up a flight pack from *Rocket Rangers*. You’re the support ship, the blue cursor. Press the bottom button to shoot anything that isn’t me.”

The starting screen loaded, showing a nondescript avatar in leather clothing with a patchwork attempt at a jetpack strapped to their back.



*Rocket Rangers* wasn't the fastest way to gain access to flight, but since the system was built around buying new models and upgrades, it would theoretically allow for a large amount of customization. Any gear Cyber Geek couldn't properly control was too risky to bring into the field. Better to work toward a tool he could fine-tune than grab something easy and less reliable.

Agent Quantum fiddled with the controller for a few moments before gamely wiggling the joystick and opening fire on an empty field the player was flying over. The digital bullets rained down upon the meager stalks of wheat, ignored by the background art. He'd figured out the controls; that was a step in the right direction.

"Here's my concern." Donald waited until they were beginning to fire; having something else to occupy their attention made it less awkward to speak so frankly. "Our teams don't really get along. We can skate over the why, but it's true. I'm fully in support of you learning from someone more experienced and improving. I'm less sure that we're the right people to teach you. Aside from barely being past rookie level ourselves, why not pick someone your team doesn't have friction with?"

"Because they don't see those teams as their rivals." To Donald's surprise, Agent Quantum was unflustered by the point; he'd come in ready to address it. "You are right, our people have friction. What you might not realize is that part of why my team doesn't get along with yours is because of respect. You're succeeding at the job we can't seem to grasp correctly, you're beloved by people overall, and you consistently manage to power through every challenge presented. Whatever issues my team has, they're exceptional at threat evaluation. The New Science Sentries see your people as their main competition, which means they've acknowledged you to be capable. How many other teams at our level do you think they hold in such esteem?"

As he was talking, Agent Quantum's cursor grew faster, identifying the more dangerous targets and opening fire. It hadn't taken him long to grasp the game, despite his apparent lack of familiarity. Then again, it was a point-and-press-a-button situation. Donald hadn't exactly started him on *Soul Grinder*.

"Because they don't like us, they'll be willing to learn from us?" Donald really needed Ren as a consultant for this ego-based nonsense.

“Because they want to surpass you, they’ll pay attention to everything you say and do. Both to learn, and to search for weaknesses.” Agent Quantum managed to look sheepish at that, though just barely. “Not the greatest of motivations, but if they learn to be better superheroes in the process, I can’t be picky about what gets them to take the lessons.”

Toggling through the meager supply of weapons offered so early in the game, Donald rained three grenades down on the spot where the level boss would spawn. They landed just as the large man with a comically oversized gun loaded, blasting him past the first two combat phases and right into the finale, where he turned red and blinking. Donald could do this part essentially from memory—he’d long ago mastered the early level patterns. It was in the later stages, where randomization came into play, that progress would slow down.

“Although I’m still not sure it’s the best idea, I’ll run it by my team. If they say yes, we can try it for a night or two. If they say no, then it’s a no. Much as I’d like to help, I can’t have them feeling unsteady out in the field. We’re not as strong as you. We have to stay focused to be on top of our game, and the people out there calling for help deserve that from us.” Donald noted that Agent Quantum’s cursor was now darting around the screen, taking out the minions as they spawned, leaving Donald free to finish off the boss. “Should that happen, I’ll try to point you toward some other good candidates. Ren’s been here since the last confluence. He knows pretty much everyone on the new teams, and he’s sparred against most of them, too.”

“Entirely reasonable,” Agent Quantum said. “Given how things have gone between our people so far, I appreciate that you’re even willing to entertain the idea.”

With an on-screen explosion, the level boss died, spewing coins and parts that Donald would be using to start customizing the jetpack. He’d need to get some stabilizers and a few safety features before feeling confident enough to pull this thing into the real world. If it failed midair, Cyber Geek might be in for quite the tumble.

As the level transition screen appeared, Donald finally looked away from the TV. “I’m impressed you were able to come make the request. In your shoes, I doubt I’d have even thought to shadow another team, and I’m sure asking this couldn’t have been easy.”

“In the interest of directing credit where it’s due, the truth is I didn’t have the idea. Your friend Tori suggested it. She holds you in clear respect, and the more I see, the more I understand why.” Agent Quantum set the controller aside, rising to his feet. “Thank you for your time, Cyber Geek. I know you’ve got training, as do I, so I’ll leave you to think things over. If you have more questions or want to talk, I’ll be around.”

The two shook hands, and on impulse, one made a snap decision. “When we’re out of the masks, you can call me Donald. Wouldn’t hurt to be on more friendly terms.”

“In that case, please feel free to call me Austin.”

It was a nice moment, one that Donald dearly hoped he’d be able to communicate well when trying to sell this idea to his team. All things considered, it would probably be easier to take down another monster unleashed by Nexus than to sell them on this notion.

Then again, since when did he think being a superhero meant taking the easy path?



Lozora limped her way into the cave, annoyed for the first time by just how out of the way this lair was. It was necessary—one didn’t take on the Alliance of Heroic Champions in broad daylight until everything was good and ready—but running here after eating that cab driver was still quite a hike. Especially injured.

He came from the back, clad in a pure black suit. In the beginning, he’d had no name, nor any need for one. Recently, however, he’d begun to go by Wendel Worthington. Recruiting more broadly meant his business dealings had been forced into the mundane world, where huge stacks of money didn’t buy the same kind of “no questions asked” sales that their market offered. There was no way around it: they needed a figurehead, a name to give the pawns. Lozora’s was off the table; she couldn’t risk revealing herself and losing whatever nebulous protection Captain Bullshit had provided. Since her employer’s true moniker was a secret even from her, Wendel had been born. There was something else to it, too, a joke or barb she didn’t quite get but could still tell was there; however, on the hierarchy of mysteries about her boss, inside jokes were clearly at the bottom.

Given the polished appearance tonight, he was probably heading out for another meeting. Lozora had no idea what this part of the plan was, nor was she especially concerned. She'd signed on with a legend specifically because she didn't want to sweat all the details. After years of being cooped up, Lozora was ready for a little fun. Perhaps she'd start by picking easier targets for the next recruiting session.

"Issues?" He didn't sound worried, more like he was prepared to be angered by her disappointment. Those dark eyes scanned down to her leg, which was almost back to holding normal pressure, though not quite.

"Turns out Toon lives up to the reputation. He and Vaudeville were a no, but most of the others signed on. You provide the tech and the timeline when the capes will be busy, they'll pounce. We're getting up there in numbers. No major players, but plenty of small fish mad they missed the Ridge City Riots."

"Strap a bomb to a roach, it explodes just as well as a bomb strapped to a person. What matters most is the bomb, the equipment they're given. I can make them capable enough to be distractions. That's all they need to manage." The man going by Wendel Worthington absorbed Lozora's news slowly. "I presume from the injury that Vaudeville and Toon are both still alive."

Lozora turned as vicious a glare as she dared onto Wendel. "The pair famous for being impossible to hurt or kill, just like I warned you before the approach? Yeah, they're doing just fine. I didn't give any details, though, so even if they wanted to cause trouble, they wouldn't know where to start."

A loose end. One he might tie up, if time permitted. So many years of planning, finally given a chance to bear fruit—he couldn't risk the unseen variables causing complications. The world was filled with so-called "unkillable" beings, but in his experience, that really meant they just hadn't encountered someone truly dedicated to wiping them out. In a world like theirs, teeming with all manner of meta-elements, unknown magics, and fluid laws of science, nothing *could* be truly permanent or invulnerable. There was always a weakness, always a tactic—he believed that down to the darkest parts of his bones. It was just a matter of whether or not one had the will and the wiles to triumph.

As for Lozora, she was tense, waiting to see if failure meant he'd try to kill her. While he felt certain the task was achievable, it was also a poor use of resources. Lozora had far more connections to the villains of her

generation than he could ever hope to achieve. Aside from which, she'd been powerful enough to warrant top-level security at Rookstone. A fight he could win, and a fight he could win without injury or loss, were two different matters. Especially in the heart of his lair, with so many inventions within easy smashing range.

"In the rear, you'll find a chair with a large metal circle around it, emitting a soft red light. Strap in. It can accelerate your healing."

"I heal fine on my own, thanks." Lozora appeared to relax without actually easing up, but the gesture itself was the point.

He didn't begrudge her resistance. This time, it really was a machine designed to heal; that didn't mean he hadn't also dummied up a few "medical" inventions that actually killed the user. It was a favorite trick of his—pretend to offer an olive branch and strike while their guard was down.

"Then take some time to rest. Recruitment is nearly done. I do need you to pick up an order in a few days, when it's ready. Something special, and specific. Will you be recovered in time?"

Lozora stared, and he stared back: she wondering what answer would trigger an attempt at murder, he pondering whether she could continue to be helpful. "I'll be fine by tomorrow. Just needed a good meal, which my driver was kind enough to provide." A long, purple tongue flicked out, giving a peek at the rows of sharp teeth normally hidden behind her lips. Intentional or not, it was a not-so-subtle reminder that he wasn't the only monster in the lair.

"Very well, then. I'll have the details ready when it's time for pickup. Until then, focus on recovery. I can have some food ordered."

"I prefer to hunt my own." There was a predatory gleam in her eye, one the masquerading Wendel paid no mind to. She could entertain whatever fantasies she liked about tearing into his flesh: one bite is all it would take for her to realize the mistake.

He hoped she held off until after the next job, at least. It would be very inconvenient to kill her with so much work still left to do.

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## Chapter 54

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When Tori had first come to the new guild—what she'd begun to think of as Villain Island—the enterprise had seemed excessive. That sentiment had steadily faded the more she'd actually used the facilities, and as Tori headed down the hall to meet with Lance, she was thankful they were doing this far from Ridge City. There was something to be said for not being directly under an enemy's nose, even if doing things that way was more daring.

Everyone else was already waiting, as they'd likely come on their own schedules rather than catch a ride with Ivan, who was off at a clandestine gathering of his own. He played his mundane, normal role to a hilt, and that included driving almost aggressively within the law. They'd gotten more than a few honking horns and shaking fists; she'd have loved to see some of the fearsome drivers actually try to make good on the foul words they spat.

Hurrying in, Tori grabbed an open seat at the table. This meeting room was like most of the others scattered around the guild: built to hold up to eight human-sized bodies, or a small number of the more unwieldy members. There were larger options, but for a four-person group, there was no need to take up the more spacious resources, if Lance could even have booked them. After months of being shut down, and with a fancy new lair to play in, the guild was more alive than Tori had previously seen it, not that she'd had much of a sample size before the Ridge City Riots. Still, better make the most of the room while they had it.

"I know, I know, I'm late. Rode over with Pseudonym. You can catch me up on the highlights, and I'll get details from Beverly on what I missed. We don't have to restart."

“Not a problem. We’re mostly just going over the pitch as a whole right now.” Lance was as cheery as ever; his personable nature always seemed a strange fit for a man working in a guild of villainy.

Across the table, Warren boasted a less congenial expression, but Tori didn’t take it personally, especially when he offered a wave of greeting. She’d come to realize that was just Warren’s way, in the same sense that she and Ivan had their brusque moments. When shit hit the fan, he’d sided with their team and the guild over his own mentor; looking constantly grumpy didn’t matter worth a damn compared to his steadfast loyalty.

“Since the guild reopened, Warren and I have been picking up odd jobs here and there—mostly surveillance and support, given our powers,” Lance continued. That fit. With his swarms of insects to command and see through the eyes of, Lance would be one of the most capable non-technological surveillance options among the guild’s members. Most people in their field knew to sweep for devices called bugs; far fewer cared about the actual namesake. As for Warren, the ability to create magic in the form of drawn symbols meant he had a large amount of versatility. Plus, while he’d turned out to be a traitor, Balaam hadn’t done a poor job training his apprentice.

“It’s been a good way to get our feet back under us, plus pick up some spare cash. But recently, a job came around that we’re interested in working. The issue is the teams can’t be smaller than four people. I’ll tell you up front: it’s nothing too involved on our part. In theory, we could go the whole night without so much as a blip of action.”

“Or...” Beverly let the word hang, an implied question demanding to be spoken.

Lance didn’t shy away. “Or we might end up in a fight, though that’s not ideal. We don’t actually know much about what this job is, only that they need a fair amount of people running security. We’d be one of the outermost teams. Our primary job would be to keep passersby from going down the wrong street. If a cape shows up, we call in the alert so the real workers have time to finish or flee.”

Interesting. Minimal risk, presumably enough pay to warrant the effort, if Lance and Warren were roping them in, and technically, they didn’t even need to commit any crimes. When it came to tasks that had to be handled in costume, working as a lookout was about as legal an option as the guild presented.

“Why the four-person teams?” Tori asked. The more she understood, the better an idea she’d have of whether or not this was a good fit.

“Coverage.” Warren looked slightly more interested than he had at the start—quite a change, by his standards. “We need to be able to hold a sizable area. With Lance’s bugs and just me, it would be tight. Having you both along, plus potentially some tech to crack into security cameras, makes it a lot more manageable.”

“Possible, but I’d need the timeframe and general locale. Getting into a single closed system, like the museum, is one thing, but if we’re covering a big area, that would entail multiple buildings with their own securities.” A rogue idea struck her, even as she was listing the difficulties. “Although, if it’s anywhere residential, I could build something to hop on the wi-fi signals of all those home cameras that show the feed online. Those are much less protected.”

From her side, Beverly tapped her nails along the table. “I take it you want me to be eyes in the sky?”

To Tori’s surprise, Lance shook his head. “Nothing as overt as a dragon flying around. We’d be leaning on you if anything physical came up. I’ve picked up some new bugs, and Warren’s got his own tricks, but neither of us can fight like Bahamut. If we need to substantially dissuade someone from heading in a direction, you’re our strongest bet.”

It was almost comical to hear that, given Lance’s sizable muscles and Beverly’s comparatively slender form. But he was right. When she turned into that green dragon, Beverly became big, tough, and downright deadly. One good thing about being in a guild of villains: none of them held prideful delusions about their strength. Everyone in this room knew they weren’t the best, or the most powerful. It was an impossible fantasy, given the councilors who ruled this organization. Some were wounded by that fact, others grew from it. Judging by the team he was building, Lance appeared to be in the latter camp.

“Hate to be pushy, but the timeframe is a big one for me. I’ve got more than a few eyes in my direction, not to mention some Tori commitments that I can’t let Hephaestus overtake. It would be suspicious.” Also, Tori was fairly sure if she tried to double-book a Starscouts meeting, Ivan would have other ideas.

“I figured,” Lance replied. “That’s why I called the meeting today, as a matter of fact; an operational date was only determined last night. It’s



supposed to go down this weekend, on Saturday evening. We'll be in a modest city named Ebnerville. The operation won't be near civilians, but since we're a far perimeter team, we might be—I'll look into that for you, Tori. Our job is to watch for intruders and capes, keeping them away at all costs."

What Tori found most fascinating about the situation were all the elements they weren't being given. Limited information, tightly controlled area, weight put largely on keeping anyone who wasn't supposed to be there away. There were probably a great many reasons the guild could have for setting up these sorts of situations, yet there was only one that Tori had already born witness to. A code enforcement—which was a nice way to say brutal execution—would demand that sort of security. Based on how the one she'd seen had gone, it would be over in no time, and they could be on their way. That had been Ivan, though. No telling who was running this one, or who they were up against. Definitely still some risk, even if it was risk that could be mitigated.

"Timing should be clear—easy enough to slip away on a Saturday. We haven't gotten to the real heart of the matter, however." Tori leaned in, making no efforts to conceal the greed in her eyes. Such pretense had no place in these halls. "How much does it *pay*?"

"Ten thousand per person, with an expectation of roughly four hours' work." He'd been ready for that, and appeared to take some joy in the momentary widening of Tori's eyes.

Sure, that was a lot less than they'd made on the museum heist, but they'd also been doing all the planning and had borne the entirety of the risk. To be paid that much for a simple lookout role... Tori felt her suspicions of the true job dial up, but ten grand was nothing to sneeze at. Especially if she could start picking up more of these gigs, the way Warren and Lance were. Beyond that, though, part of Tori simply wanted to grasp at the chance to wear her suit again. She'd put in so much work and had barely gotten to take it out from the garage. She liked being Hephaestus, and this was as fine an excuse as any.

"Count me in. Advertising revenue online isn't what it used to be," Beverly said.

"I'll need to double-check my schedule, but short of a conflict, you can expect me to show up." Even as she agreed, Tori thought about Ivan's meeting, the one he'd been in no hurry to get to. Given the job she'd just

heard pitched, part of her wondered if Ivan was getting the other half of the operation explained to him at that very moment.



In truth, Ivan had gotten the details corresponding to Tori's task in the first five minutes of the meeting's start. It was more a footnote to him than a matter of primary concern. That might have changed, had he known his former apprentice intended to be part of the lookout team; however, the councilors had more vital matters to deal with.

All seven were gathered, staring at a hologram in the center of the table. The details were grainy, but one thing was clear. The objects depicted were vast, and numerous.

"I'll be the asshole," Morgana announced, seemingly apropos of nothing. "Wade, are you completely sure about this? It's hard to believe something so huge could be coming and we've yet to hear a blip from the AHC."

"A reasonable, if slightly wounding, concern." Wade was unbothered by the doubt. It was almost tradition for someone to ask such a question at this point in the situational breakdown, hence Morgana's vulgar declaration. "But yes, I am extremely certain. Many years back, after *someone* had an extraterrestrial encounter—" Wade paused to fire a pointed look in Ivan's direction "—I took the time to place surveillance stations and satellites in deep space. Professor Quantum never saw the same need that I did for such expansive early warning systems. That's also why the image is so bad; the tech is decades out of date. Regardless, yes, I am confident in this. My best guess is that, within a week, the AHC will know as well."

"That doesn't leave very long for the capes to prepare before they arrive." Stasis, for a change, was engaged in the discussion. Even to her, potential alien invaders held the spark of novelty. "Sneak attack?"

A loud *clang* echoed as Xelas dropped her arm to the table, looking up to the ceiling; perhaps lost in thought, perhaps scanning the skies. "It would have to be, after what the Grzzniltan ship saw. Except, that's what's bugging me. They got a good look at the AHC on full display. Outside of us, what whacko sees power like that and starts spoiling for a fight? Is it possible these beings are stronger?"

The universe was a vast place, and theirs was only a single planet among countless. It would be ridiculous to assume that the strongest of Earth was also the strongest across the entire galaxy.

Fortunately, they didn't have to rely on assumptions. With a neutral tone, Ivan rattled off the information. "To the best we've discerned, Earth is one of the more powerful planets among those with spacefaring intelligent life. Likely due to our tremendous concentration of meta-humans, as well as our own fundamental instincts toward combat. I once had occasion to compete in something of a gladiatorial event on an alien spacecraft, and they were not prepared to face Fornax's might."

"Space tournament? That sounds fun!" Xelas cried. "I can't believe you didn't invite us. So greedy. You'd probably still have won."

Ivan shook his head. "It was well before the guild, and I didn't win. Nobody did, technically. Things got... complicated."

Before they got too far down that tangent, Wade brought everyone's attention back to the front. "Our larger concern is the planet's future, not Ivan's past. As this is a threat that represents the potential to impact the guild, as well as our individual holdings and families, a response is necessary. We could theoretically kick this information over to the AHC, giving them extra time to prepare and buying some goodwill in the process."

It was Gork, who rarely spoke, who cut the idea off at the knees. "No. They came for us in our home. They dragged us into the streets. They wanted to do it alone. Let them."

There came a murmur of agreement from nearly every mouth, with two notable exceptions. Still, the consensus was clear, so Wade didn't waste the time calling for a vote. Better to keep the momentum going while they had it.

"Very well. That means we'll need to set to work on the other options: how are we going to protect what's ours? Because whoever sent an alien armada our way is playing a complicated game, and I'm certain we've yet to see all the pieces."

"I hate these sorts of overly complicated schemes. If that's how they want to do it, then let's go with my favorite counter." There was an unexpected darkness to Arcanicus as he rose from his chair. Time had stolen much of his aggression, yet under the surface, there still simmered enough rage to remind those watching of how he'd come to join the guild in

the first place. An invasion of the planet was an invasion of the guild's territory, and that had managed to stir a touch of the older man's wrath.

“Let's incinerate the entire game board.”

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## Chapter 55

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If there was one upside to confronting his father—and at this point, even that seemed like a stretch—it was that looking at pictures of the beach had stopped causing such pronounced reactions in Rick. He was no longer at odds with his own mind, groping for memories that weren't where they were supposed to be. Now that he understood, the fits of panic had faded. Unfortunately, what they'd left in their place was a constant boulder of dread in his stomach.

Clicking about, he opened yet another tab, evaluating a potential meta-human from history to see if his dad fit the bill. There was no reason for this. Ivan had been clear that when Rick was ready to ask, he would answer. But it was still insane to picture, his father butchering people. An army, at that. They must have been fairly weak for him to take out that many. If Ivan had ever been a major bad guy, then the AHC would have locked him up. Wouldn't they?

Fleeting, Rick's mind flashed to the guild of villains that had been revealed last year. He nearly skimmed right past the notion, as he had several times already. It was just a step too far. His dad hiding his past was one thing; an entire secret life felt like a flight of fancy.

Except... now that Rick was in the right headspace, he thought back to the metal-armored person who saved him and Beth when their school was attacked. That suit sure hadn't looked like it was designed by a cape, and Rick had yet to catch sight of it anywhere since, even online.

Was it possible their dad had sent a fellow villain out to protect his kids? That begged the question, though, why not come himself if he knew there

was danger? Distance, most likely, although something about that still felt off. The kind of man who kills an army for threatening his family didn't mesh with someone who'd trust someone else to protect his kids during a riot. Rick was sure there was a reason, if his hunch was right, he just wasn't certain he'd want to know what it was.

That was the dilemma set before him. Learning that one little bit about Ivan had rocked Rick to his foundation, and all signs indicated there was a lot more to hear. His curiosity had been sated: he knew he wasn't crazy. If there was a point to walk away, this was it. This was the best opportunity he had to preserve his relationship with his father as it stood. One story had changed everything; there was truly no guessing how Rick would feel once he knew it all.

A knock on his door was followed by five seconds of courtesy waiting—he was a teenage boy with a computer—followed by Janet slowly easing the door open. “Came to see if you needed anything. You’ve been locked up for a while.”

Things had been strained since the revelation. Knowing what Ivan had done also entailed learning about his mother's complicity. Rick's initial impulse was to send her away, just like he'd been doing so far. Only this time, her timing was better. She'd caught him in a state of uncertainty, where getting guidance mattered more than holding his grudge.

“Are you a meta-human, too?” Rick looked to her, away from the screen—the first time he'd made such a concession in several days.

Quietly, Janet shut the door behind her, even though Juan was getting dinner and Beth was still on her field trip. “No. Never have been, and never especially felt the urge to change that. Powers make things more complicated.”

“So, our family smarts...”

“Just a lot of academics falling in love, along with growing up in an environment that emphasized learning,” Janet assured him.

Rick snorted at that, then looked embarrassed, before remembering he was supposed to be stern. “You sure broke that cycle with Dad.” Ivan was not an especially dumb man, but he'd never held the same passion for sciences and learning that captivated most of the family.

For a moment, Janet almost tried to deny the assessment, before merely sighing with a shake of her head. “I was at a rebellious point in my life, and I wanted to meet people other than lifelong devotees of education. Your

father... well, he was unlike anyone I'd ever met before. Willful, unyielding, full of pride that had been hard earned."

"Not to mention, a killer."

The past faded from Janet's eyes as she snapped her head up. "A protector."

"He told me he slaughtered an army."

"Ivan would butcher an entire planet if they collectively threatened you or Beth. It's one of the traits I most respect in him." There was a hardness in his mother's face that Rick hadn't been prepared for. Deep down, he'd wondered how she could have gone along with this, speculating that perhaps she'd been kept partially in the dark. With that expression, all deniability was gone. She'd known exactly who he was.

"You don't... that's a *bad* thing, Mom. He shouldn't be that eager to kill."

This time, her face softened slightly. Her hand twitched, like she was tempted to reach out and offer comfort but feared it would be refused.

"Rick, your father took no joy in that day. Given the chance, I sincerely think he would live the rest of his life in peace. But when someone comes to do harm to your children, as a parent, you fight them with every ounce of strength in your body. Ivan's strength just happens to be higher than most fathers'."

That was a hard one to debate, and a point Rick's own mind had been raising. Awful as the image of his dad killing an army was, what was the better option? Letting them storm the shores, hurting innocent people in the process, permitting harm to come to his own family? Would Rick have respected those choices more? Even capes occasionally took lives in battle, albeit as a last resort.

Instead, Rick turned his attention to another matter. One that had haunted him in various forms for years now and had rediscovered a new form to take with Ivan's revelation. "Is this the reason you got divorced? I did the math. Less than a year after the incident happened, you filed for separation."

For the first time, Janet looked away. It took her a moment to compose herself, but when she turned back to Rick, she looked the same as ever—which might actually be more worrying in a way, had Rick been given time to properly consider it.

“No, seeing Ivan kill that army wasn’t what drove us apart. Your father didn’t lie to me. I knew who he was when we said our vows. He’s the same man, the same dad, he’s been all your life. Only now, you’re learning he’s also more.” Janet paused, deciding that this was as opportune a moment as she’d get. “Have you given any more thought to this weekend?”

“Still... deciding,” Rick admitted, not quite meeting her eye. This weekend was supposed to be spent at his dad’s house. The question was whether or not Rick actually wanted to go. Skips and trades happened; there were plenty of excuses he could use that Beth would buy. Ivan, on the other hand, would know.

Janet got up, smoothing over the section of bed where she’d perched. “Take your time. You know your room there is always open when you’re ready.” She retreated to the hallway quickly, content to take her victory of a short conversation before things turned south.

Because, while Rick didn’t know it, he’d been sniffing around a major sore spot, one that Janet wasn’t sure she could hold her composure through. Ivan killing the army hadn’t changed things between them; that much was true. She’d known her husband’s true power and identity, and certainly didn’t disagree with him killing to protect their family.

It was what had come next that had caused the problem. With an invading army reported and Fornax in combat, there was no surprise that *she’d* been called. In less than five minutes after the army was gone, Lodestar arrived, bursting onto the scene in a shower of sand and golden light. Such a simple moment, and yet, it had been the beginning of the end for their marriage.

That was the day Janet realized that no matter how devoted a husband he might be, Ivan would never truly love her. Not when his heart so clearly belonged to someone else.



“For the record, this is bullshit.”

“No, Presto. This is a favor that is being done *for* us, and if you can’t keep a civil tongue through it, then you can go back to the AHC for training.” Agent Quantum was sterner than usual. Generally, he tended to



ignore Presto's running chatter on the channels. Everyone was a little tense tonight, given the situation.

Perched up on a rooftop, the New Science Sentries watched as Hat Trick threw a multicolored scarf from her sleeve onto a mugger's gun, wrapping up the entire thing. He fired, producing a muffled gunshot from within the cloth, followed by a brief yelp of pain. In the time he'd been distracted, Cyber Geek had dashed over, hitting him with a giant blue mallet that caused cartoon sound effects while also knocking the target unconscious.

"Handy trick. Not so easy to do when you're using real punches," Tachyonic muttered. He shut himself up after a quick nudge from Agent Quantum. This was a hard enough sell for the team; having the second-in-command question the move would only make things worse. "At least Medley is handling it our way."

That was true, in the sense that Medley was engaged in melee combat with two more muggers—one human, and one with long, whip-like appendages growing from his arms. Every time the whips landed, they eroded whatever they touched, from concrete to Medley's scales. He'd been dipping in and out of battle, holding both of his antagonists' attention. Just as the whip-man came in for an attack, Medley jumped to the side, revealing Cold Shoulder with a hefty blast of chill. The whips and the man wielding them were encased in instant ice, though the sections around the whip-appendages immediately started to liquefy.

The mugger made a dash, but Medley was already on him, and this time he wasn't playing the distraction. A quick blow to the leg took the man out, after which Medley patted him down for weapons, producing a well-used knife and a gun that appeared to have never been fired.

"I don't get it. They beat up a bunch of muggers. We've done that." Unlike the other two, Plasmodia sounded more confused than bothered by the scenario, though she'd slipped plenty of the latter feeling in there, too. "What are we supposed to be taking from this?"

"It's the first job, of the first night," Agent Quantum reminded her. "We're going to shadow them for a full week. Keep an open mind."

"Since our fearless leader says to be on board, I guess I'll point out one difference in their approach. Have you all noticed the injury count?" Presto pointed to the criminals who were being tied up. Cyber Geek had pulled out a gun that shot freezing energy and was keeping the whip-man iced until

transportation could arrive. “The worst one of the lot is that guy who fired the gun, which was his own fault for shooting in that situation. Based on our stats, we’d have broken around three bones, and needed medical attention for at least one.”

Sometimes, it was dangerously easy to forget that, under all the bullshit, Ike had an incredibly capable mind. Plasmodia pivoted her head, eyes half-crossed as she did her own mental math. “Are you sure about that?”

“Absolutely. It’s in the nature of our tactics. Professor Quantum taught us to go for the takedown if the threat is real; the less the enemy rampages, the fewer civilians can be caught in the crossfire.”

That did make sense, from Agent Quantum’s point of view. Trouble was, the more they stuck to those methods, the more things went awry. If hitting softer was one of the differences between Cyber Geek’s team and the New Science Sentries, then Agent Quantum needed to understand how that factored in. That might not be the right tactic for his people, but he couldn’t make the call appropriately until he understood why it mattered.

Agent Quantum just hoped he could convince the team to keep going along with it. They still had quite a lot of week left to get through.



On another building, a different shape watched the same show. This was no great, major event, but every now and then, things took a wild turn. Nexus wasn’t expecting much. This was more him monitoring to track how things were shaping up. Seeing Cyber Geek helping the New Science Sentries filled him with great joy, simple a moment as it appeared. That didn’t always happen; in plenty of versions, pride proved too great a hurdle.

Nexus did love when they went this way, however. It opened up new potentials, ones that few worlds ever got to catch even the barest glimpses of. For the upcoming show, it had the potential to add several unexpected layers. He was so excited, he could hardly wait. But wait he would, as the event’s kickoff was still plodding along through space, dragging their unseen secret weapon with them.

He smiled as he looked down to the street, where all three criminals had been so expertly captured. While there might be some time left before the main event, he luckily had a few warm-up bouts to sustain him. One of

which should be coming very soon, assuming this world paced with those similar. The potential for surprise was why Nexus kept coming back, even though he knew the beats by heart.

There was always a chance that this time could be different, a truth he found infinitely amusing.

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## Chapter 56

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“Tori, grab the glitter before it falls off the table. Newton, watch out, you nearly hit Trudy’s glue. Ivan, any ETA on that next round of snacks?”

Helen stood in the middle of the storm, directing children and staff alike as they zipped around working on their banner for next week’s End of Summer Shindig. Soon, all of them would be gathered with the rest of the local clusters for several days of camping, activities, competition, and general fun. It was the year’s big kickoff, a way to ease the blow of summer’s end for the kids coping with a return to school. Preparations had been underway while Tori was busy being kidnapped, but it was clear her absence had caused little to no impact with Helen at the wheel. More impressive was that Helen was never harsh or demanding with the kids: only firm, supportive, and shockingly patient. Ivan had really lucked out when they paired him up.

Not that he was having trouble blending in. As Ivan made his way in from the kitchen, a bevy of toasted mini-sandwiches and homemade tiny pizzas stacked upon a tray in his hands, Tori could have easily pictured him wandering into one of her own childhood meetings. He would have fit in perfectly. Huge purple oven mitts that he didn’t even need, a borrowed apron, and a mildly uncertain expression, he looked like pretty much every dad she’d ever seen roped into pitching in—except, he was happy to be there. Well, he seemed happy if one knew how to read Ivan’s stalwart nature.

Across the table, Beth was hunched over, deep in concentration as she scrawled bubble lettering, attempting to capture the entire cluster’s roster in

her fanciest handwriting. As one of the older kids present, it had fallen to her to handle such a delicate task. So far, there had been no flare-ups or issues with those silver blades, and if Tori didn't know better, she'd have had no idea Beth was a meta-human. Tori wondered, aware that she could probably never ask, how much of Beth's control was inherent, versus trained. Was it possible Ivan had been giving Beth side-instruction, or were the AHC's new programs for helping non-apes control their powers really that good? It was an issue to keep in mind—that pool could be used for recruitment with minimal effort. After all, who was going to say no if someone like Professor Quantum or Lodestar told a new meta they had the makings of a superhero?

Beth, hopefully—not that Tori imagined it would ever reach that point. Ivan would certainly step in long before his daughter went the path of the capes. Otherwise, the guild would end up having to add new rules to the code about keeping miles away from her any time she was in costume, lest they meet Fornax's wrath.

Tori forced her mind away from superheroes, centering on the night she was dealing with. It wasn't often she got to spend time on something entirely normal, and while the circumstances of getting here were undeniably meta-tinged, the nights themselves were completely mundane. She turned her attention to corralling the kids, aiming them as best she could back toward the various sections of the banner. There was an area near the top where Helen had the children with high energy shaking glitter cannisters all over the place—mercifully, she'd laid down plastic sheeting in advance. Sooner or later, even children could wear themselves out, and once they were tuckered Helen shifted them to a different activity.

Mallory was working on making lists of supplies they would need, taking it a step further to create customized checklists for each of her peers, complete with bright marker-colored boxes to cross off. When they could pry Loyce away from the snack trays, she was aiding Trudy with making the campground decorations. Considering that the materials for these were of the craft paper and popsicle stick variety, they were crafting some surprisingly substantial displays. Caden, meanwhile, was laying out the supplies for a paper mâché project, though Tori noticed him getting restless. With a quick check on Newton, who was losing steam on the glitter cannisters, and a look to Helen for confirmation, she decided it was time for a change-out.

When Tori brought Caden over, Helen was waiting, glitter can at the ready as she slapped it into Caden's hands. A child with a chance to make a mess needs little direction; without a word, Caden had joined the others, jumping and shaking the can of sparkles with all his tiny might. Helen took a few steps away, dodging Newton as he bolted across the room to take over on paper mâché; though, if she was hoping to spare her outfit from rogue shimmer, that battle was long since lost.

"Holding up okay? Need anything?" The words were carefully whispered, and never broke the happy grin on Helen's face that was turned toward the kids. It wasn't the first time she'd checked in on Tori that night, but she also hadn't been excessive about it.

"I'm fine, really. Although kidnappings are not my favorite activity, it's not like I haven't already been through some rough spots. Office attack, club attack, nearly getting crushed in the street—that's just life in Ridge City, you know?"

Helen nodded; however, there was an expression on her face that Tori couldn't quite place. Concern, probably, though if she hadn't known better, she'd have thought it was edging over into guilt. "You are unquestionably a tough, capable person, but even those types have to let it out sometimes. If you ever need help, please don't be afraid to ask."

Much as Tori would have liked to callously brush the whole thing aside and put the idea to bed, she couldn't exactly be rude to Ivan's friend, especially one who was helping out so much with the cluster. Past that, there was something sincere about Helen, in a way that itched Tori's brain yet she couldn't quite put a finger on. Whatever it was, it turned lines that should have sounded like hollow pleasantries into genuine care. Even for Tori, it was hard to be shitty when she believed someone was truly trying to make things better.

"Thanks. Not sure I'll take you up on that, but the sentiment is appreciated."

"All I can do is offer." Helen's face suddenly twisted in worry as she darted into the fray. "One sandwich at a time, Loyce! Just because they're small doesn't mean you can't choke on them."



Emory was dripping in sweat as the last of the machines slipped back into the wall. Overhead, the large clock had reached zero, meaning he was finally permitted a few moments to rest. Near collapsing, he grabbed a bottle of water from the small cubby built into the wall by the door. It was one of the only places in this chamber that wouldn't be in peril, mostly by virtue of sliding behind an armored wall when the clock started. Slamming the liquid as fast as he could, Emory tried to catch his breath at the same time. It seemed a fool's errand, but after over a week of this, he was nearly getting it down.

"Very nice." Xelas's voice echoed through the room, coming from unseen speakers woven through the design. "A few more like that, and we'll be ready to step you up a notch."

In the beginning, Emory had argued. He'd complained, asking why he needed to fight these mechanical opponents, overcome these painful, yet not lethal, traps. For a long time, Xelas had said nothing. It was only a few days prior that he'd finally been given an answer. The words rang in his head as he guzzled the water. They'd been haunting him ever since, seeping all the way down to his bones.

"Why the training?" It was the first time he'd seen her turn serious, a sharp indicator of what was to come. "Because your power isn't all that impressive, and I don't want you to die right out of the gate. I want you to be skilled enough to survive for a full year. But if you don't want that, we can call it anytime you like."

Emory yearned to reject that idea, yet he couldn't. The fate of his gang was proof that there were leagues far greater than the one he'd been playing in, and now, he was around meta-humans using an entirely different scale of power. If there was one lesson Emory had taken from his gang's slaughter, it was that death came swift and without warning. The only ones who'd walked away that night were the powerful ones, like Xelas.

If Emory wanted to live, to survive, perhaps one day even to thrive in their world, then he needed to be stronger. Meeting Xelas's standards was the first step, with untold more to come. Polishing off the rest of his water, Emory placed the bottle back into the cubby, then nodded up at the clock.

"Ready for another round."

Xelas was almost purring this time. "You know, I really didn't expect to enjoy having a pet this much, but that attitude does make it fun. Very well, my little apprentice. Ask, and you shall receive."



“Okay, you’ve been staring at your phone for a full five minutes now. Everyone okay, or did you find the mother of all entrancing gifs?”

The words yanked Beverly from her fugue. Chloe was right, she had indeed been lost in thought for some time. Together, they were sitting on the couch while an old episode of *The Meta Bunch* ran, Chloe researching some new coffee preparation technique they were trying in gastropubs while Beverly had intended to catch up on email. That plan had fallen apart when she hit the first one waiting for her, however. Tori would have been the preferable one to discuss the issue with, but it wasn’t as though this connected to anything directly villain-related.

“I got an email from my oldest brother,” Beverly explained. “He’s reaching out to see if I want to come by the house for a visit.”

Chloe perked up, showing new interest in her friend’s distraction. “I’ve been curious. You always talk about your family like you’re close, but I’ve never seen you visit or take a call from them.”

The truth was, Beverly considered herself *very* close with her family. They’d always been a unit, a team, and unfortunately, those instincts had been in full effect when she first became Bahamut. “We had something of a falling out, the night I got my powers. You have to understand, pretty much my entire family was in the service, mostly Marines. It’s a tradition that goes back generations. Before Lodestar changed the nature of war, they had plenty of chances to see traditional combat, to develop certain habits. So when a green monster suddenly burst into their home, roaring and destroying whatever it touched, they responded the way you’d expect from trained soldiers.”

“They attacked you.” Chloe could be more perceptive than her overall demeanor let on, and Beverly was glad for it. That saved her trouble of walking her all the way to the proper conclusion, even if there was still more story to tell.

“I get it, from their perspective. All they heard was my scream, a roar, and then some monster runs down the stairs. Easy to assume it’s a meta-intruder that just attacked Beverly. They opened fire on me, almost without hesitation. But I didn’t know I was bulletproof in green dragon form back then, so I was terrified. I tried to escape, except they were positioned in front of the exits in case of retreat, and I ended up slamming through



several in my scramble to get away from the bullets—before I understood, or could control my strength, mind you. I think a few of them are still wearing casts. Thank goodness no one was permanently injured.”

No matter how tight-knit a family might be, attempted murder was a tough hurdle to get past. Beverly could still see her own kin turning their weapons on her, the killing intent clear in their eyes, just as she could still feel the crunch of their bones as she tried to sweep them aside. Time and distance had been the appropriate salve for the wound as Beverly gained control and her family healed. But she was long past accidental transformations, and it sounded as though there was only so much physical mending left to do on their end. If the wound between her and her family wasn’t patched soon, it threatened to become a scar, the sort that could never fully heal.

“Your brother wants to make amends. That’s something,” Chloe pointed out.

It *was* something, that was true. Beverly just wasn’t sure it was enough. If she went before everyone was ready, it could make things worse. Ambrose was the peacemaker of the group; as the oldest child, he often ended up as the default referee on disagreements. Him being ready to talk wasn’t the same as the whole family being in a good headspace.

She wouldn’t get anywhere by sitting around speculating, though. Beverly began to type, her mind now set. “I think I’ll meet with just Ambrose for now, get a feel in person for how the family is holding up.”

“If you need a public spot with some privacy, I can let you use one of the Ridge City Grinders rooms that people rent out for meetings. Haven’t exactly been slammed on that front since the riots, anyway.”

“Thanks. I might take you up on that.” Beverly’s hands continued to move, albeit with a slight touch of hesitation. She might have no problem diving headfirst into deadly battle, but dealing with family was a far more perilous undertaking.

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## Chapter 57

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Saturday marked two major moments for Tori. The second would come much later, but the first happened quite early. Somewhere around four in the morning, Tori conducted her first fully successful test of the miniature aerosolized dispersion device. Getting the nozzle angles perfect proved to be a surprisingly tough part, as it demanded precise calculation to ensure the solution would spray only away from the user. The formula had also required a dash of fine-tuning. Its original incarnation could burn skin if the mix was even the slightest bit off. By altering a few ratios, Tori managed to produce something that was incredibly annoying, distracting, even painful, but that wouldn't cause any lasting damage. That she knew of, anyway. Probably have to run that part by Wade for testing.

It felt good to have the task cleared off her plate, but Tori didn't kick back with a cold one and relax at the accomplishment. Instead, she shifted gears to her other project of the week: fine-tuning the Hephaestus suit for the evening's activities. Tori's key goal was to recalibrate the mini-gravitational anomaly generators until the suit felt like moving in her own body. It was more efficient to shift the suit's movements than it was to relearn all of her tactics in a heavier form. The less difference there was, the more fluid she could be as Hephaestus.

That shouldn't matter, in theory, when Tori took the suit out later on. They were only working guard duty. She didn't even have any cameras to hack, as it turned out. All she needed to do was have her sensors engaged and keep scanning. Lance's bugs would be more than enough deterrent for any non-meta, plus Warren was setting up a few glyphs around the area in

advance. Beverly was the muscle, leaving Tori to handle long-distance perimeter sweeps.

That was what she kept telling herself, even as she made sure the suit's weapons systems were all showing full functionality. Whether the night would actually prove to be peaceful or not, Tori had her doubts. Every time she put that suit on, she was stepping into another world, a world where things could go very sideways, very fast. The wrong meta in the wrong place, and who knew what might happen. That was why she had to be prepared for any outcome, no matter the mission. Even as a simple lookout, Hephaestus would be ready.

Until then, there was refining to do. The job wasn't until night, which offered a much-needed opportunity for some napping. She could also show Beverly the completed prototype, once her friend was up for the day. Tori had managed to cram her Saturday quite full of activity, a not-so-subtle tactic of staying busy to keep her mind off other concerns. The habit might not be all that healthy, but it did help make her exceptionally productive, so Tori could live with the tradeoff. As Hephaestus, with almost all of her abilities tied into the suit, being a perfectionist workaholic was more likely to increase her lifespan than lessen it.

It certainly wasn't as if having fully optimized beam weapons would make her a *worse* scout, after all. Just one with more options.



The sounds of the footsteps were heavy, despite the carpeting. Ivan listened as they came, hearing both the current sounds and the countless other versions echoing from throughout the years. He could remember those footsteps when they first began, so unsure and wobbling. Then came the faster, more dangerous footsteps, careening around as stability was learned. From there, they mostly just got bigger and louder, with a few particularly happy events bringing them back to that frantic, unsure pace. Today, they sounded especially firm, like a man marching down to face judgment.

Rick emerged from the stairwell of the townhome, walking into the kitchen where Ivan was already working on a skillet full of eggs. He'd been up prepping for an hour already; Tori wasn't the only one who liked to keep busy when she felt nervous.

Sliding up to the breakfast bar, Rick sat in one of stools, looking at his father with slightly bleary eyes. There hadn't been much chance to talk the night before. Since he and Beth were dropped off together, they couldn't very well dig into the issue of Ivan's past. Neither had said anything on the matter, in fact. For a time, Ivan almost convinced himself that Rick was content to let the issue momentarily rest. Now, seeing his teenage son up just before dawn, Ivan realized that this had been his plan from the start. Rise early—the time when Beth was sleeping and Ivan was making breakfast.

“Where did you learn to cook?” Rick's tongue was still slightly weighed down by sleep, but he was fast shaking it off with the energy that only youth, and a few meta-made compositions, could provide.

“Largely self-taught, with various books and videos to help along the way.” Ivan weighed how much honesty he should divulge. Technically, Rick hadn't asked specifically about the life he'd kept hidden. Then again, should he have to? So long as Ivan stayed away from the more troubling topics, there was no reason not to shoot straight wherever possible. “I didn't have a lot of pleasures growing up. Food was one of the few things to enjoy. Once I got older, it became an interest and a hobby, something I could do that was... creative.” Ivan had almost said “non-destructive,” which was also true, just not where he wanted to aim the conversation so soon.

Rick let out a soft groan and wiped his face, clearing some sleep from his eyes. “Well, you managed to make breakfast sound cryptic, so I guess we should just get right into this.” Before he could continue, Ivan set a glass of orange juice in front of him, then motioned for Rick to go on.

“I've had some time to think about what you told me. The army, the beach, you being a meta-human... and that part, I can make peace with. Mom had your back, you know. She told me that you only did all that because they threatened us. I still don't know if wholesale slaughter was the right course in that situation, but I also get it. You were protecting your family, and in the end, since you weren't even charged with a crime, it seems strange to hold that incident against you.”

It was good news, and had the delivery not come laced with several qualifiers, Ivan might have felt a rush of hope in his chest. Sadly, it was all too clear that Rick wasn't done yet, so Ivan merely continued to cook the eggs, giving his son room to find the words.

“What bothers me is this: I know that’s not everything. If you’re fish-army-killing strong, then there’s basically zero chance that you’re some no-name meta. You have a past, a history that goes well beyond that day on the beach, and I’m guessing most of it has less noble goals than protecting your family.”

“I made a promise.” The words leapt out of Ivan’s mouth from old, nearly forgotten habit. How many times had he spit out that phrase in the face of capes, criminals, and victims alike? How many deaths because of a single vow? “Yes, Rick, I did bad things. Killed, hurt—fill in the blanks. If you want to know why, it’s because I promised vengeance to someone who was truly owed it. Some of the deeds I did in service of that goal, others to survive or gain resources, but it always went back to that promise. I’ll give you the specifics, if you want them, just be warned that we’ll be diving into one of the darkest parts of my history.”

Shaking his head, Rick downed a quarter of the juice in a single gulp. Ivan slipped the first batch of eggs, scrambled just the way he liked, onto Rick’s plate while the drink was in motion: the seamless coordination of a dad who’d cooked untold meals, while also hiding a murderous secret.

“Let’s not go that deep to start. What I was going to say is that, while not all of it could have been about protecting us, I don’t think you’d hurt people without reason. For now, I’m okay with keeping some things a mystery. There’s just a few big-ticket concerns I wanted to get out of my head.”

Still dangerous territory, though Ivan much preferred general to specific, in regards to his past. Turning his attention to the pancake batter, Ivan hoped he wasn’t about to make a major mistake. “Ask away.”

“Have you ever hurt anyone who didn’t deserve it?”

“Unquestionably, yes,” Ivan replied, no hesitation whatsoever. This was a question he’d been expecting in some form or another and had already planned out a truthful response. “Even excluding the circumstances of my own brutal upbringing, metas often work in gangs or syndicates, the more powerful ones forcing their will upon the weaker members, turning them into pawns. Pawns tend to get cut down, and I can’t expect that all of them deserved it. But that’s also the nature of combat. Step onto a battlefield, and it’s no longer about who deserves what—only those who live, and those who don’t. Outside of that, I can only say that I’ve never struck without cause. How deserving they were from there is a case-by-case question.”

Rick's eyes were wide, yet he was managing to stay composed. He'd certainly come in better prepared for the conversation this time around. After a few seconds, the shock seeped away from his face. "I guess that's fair. Even in the beach example, you couldn't have known the morality of every member of that army. It's not like you killed a superhero."

Without warning, Ivan found himself at a precipice. Two paths lay before him, truth or falsehood. It would be very easy to lie right now, to put his son's mind to rest and let the matter end. The problem was, if Rick ever found out Ivan's identity, the lie would be obvious. Fornax killing a cape was what had finally caused his and Lodestar's last real fight, and his eventual incarceration. It was a well-known piece of trivia, one that Rick would be sure to pick up. Lying when they were young had been the right call—Ivan still had no doubt of that—but he'd told Rick that they were past that phase. Another fib, and whatever they built from here would always have the potential to be destroyed at the foundation.

"Superheroes go bad sometimes. Jokull, the Silent Server, Faithful, Candlebop—all former beloved capes who turned down a dark path. That's not even including the ones like Apollo, who abused their position to try manipulating the law. I've never struck without cause. Perhaps it's best if we leave that point there."

This time, the shock didn't fade so quickly. Rick chewed on a bite of eggs to the point where there had to be nothing but largely liquid left—either processing or plotting how to run for the door, Ivan wasn't fully sure which.

"Since you mentioned Apollo, there is the matter of that guild he exposed." Rick was going slow, visibly building up his courage. "I didn't think there was any chance you could have been part of that, even knowing about the beach. But the more you talk, the deeper I'm realizing this goes. Were you one of them, pouring out of that building, fighting in the streets?"

Though he couldn't have known it, Rick left quite a large loophole for his father to exploit in that question. Ivan was sorely tempted by it, even knowing how important the truth was at this juncture. It wouldn't be worth it in the long run; however, this did offer a bit of wiggle room in regards to how specific he had to get with the response.

Ivan spooned pancake batter into the sizzling pans, hisses and pops peppering the spaces between his words. "I was not in that crowd, but to answer your larger question: yes, I am affiliated with that guild. As much as

it is a gathering of criminals, it's also a support group for those seeking to find a more mundane life... one that hasn't technically been charged with any crimes, I might add."

"Wow." Rick was past stunned, into near bewilderment. "That's... you're part of a guild of villains? What about the armored guy who saved me and Beth, you sent him?"

"No, I didn't," Ivan responded. "They learned about the danger to your school and came to help of their own accord. Because as much as it might seem like an assortment of monsters from the outside, there are people in that guild who I trust with my life. Friends who protected my family before I even knew they were in danger. So before you jump to conclusions about what that place is, keep in mind that when things went awry, my ally's first instinct was to save a school, not to run around pillaging."

With a clatter, Rick dropped his fork to the plate, eggs only half eaten. He stared down at them, trying to accept Ivan's words. "You trust a guild of villains... with your life. Do you get how insane that sounds from my side of the table? What about me and Beth, should we be making inroads with these people, too? Never know when we might need saving, and the Curdler is our only hope."

Sounds from overhead cut them both off. It seemed they'd gotten loud enough to raise Beth from her slumber. Once the smells hit, they wouldn't have much time left to talk openly. Ivan decided to finish things off with a quick piece of vital advice, one he'd be very grateful not to have to explain.

"You and Beth should be protected, but things do go wrong. If something ever happens to me, then don't bother with the guild. Get to the AHC or somewhere public—on TV, if you can manage it—and call for Lodestar."

"Because she'd just happen to be listening and choose to help us in that moment? She's not everywhere at once," Rick pointed out.

"Maybe not, but if I'm gone, then she's going to be looking for you both to make sure you're safe. I'm not *only* acquainted with villains, you know."

It was the first time all morning that Ivan had seen surprise that wasn't slightly terrified on Rick's face, and he did his best to memorize the expression. There probably wouldn't be many more like it to come if Rick kept asking questions. Eventually, they'd get to the truly horrifying stuff, and his son would never be able to look at him the same way again.

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## Chapter 58

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The mood was tense as Morgana looked over the reports, her primary team gathered at her side. On her left stood Gork; to her right was Stasis, with the remainder of the room filled by the team leads who would be running their own units.

“Based on our intel, it looks like they haven’t moved much this week. If Endless Blitz knows we’re coming, he’s not tipping his hand.”

At Morgana’s words, a ripple went through the room. They’d hunted down most of the traitors to the guild—those who were not killed the day of the riots—but a few had managed to slip away. Endless Blitz, with his power of body duplication, had been a vital asset for Balaam’s attempted uprising. It was thanks to Endless Blitz that Balaam had appeared to have gathered so many forces early on, and that same power had made the man especially tough to capture. Thus far, they’d caught three duplicates posing as the real one. This time, they’d used new scanners and some fresh magical incantations to make as sure as possible that this was him. Vengeance was finally close at hand.

“One last review before we go,” Morgana announced. It would be overkill in most situations, but former guild members were special cases. “Remember, above all else, that this is not a normal code enforcement. Endless Blitz was one of us. That means, along with being strong enough to make the cut, he knows our tricks, our tactics. He doesn’t want to die any more than the rest of us do, so we can be certain he’s laid every defense possible to hold us off. We can hate him all day, but don’t belittle the danger he presents.”



Locking eyes with each of her subordinates, Morgana made sure the point found its mark. Ego could be a danger in the field, especially when emotions ran this high. “Whisperwind, you and the magic users are going in first. Mark the real Endless Blitz, then thin out the clones so they can’t confuse us. As soon as you act, Onslaught’s team rolls in to push over whatever goons he’s got surrounding him. Horrorsaurus, your team roams the exits, making sure nobody slips away and tracking them down if they do. Gork, Stasis, and I will come through once the initial strike is made to cleave what remains. Be ready to change and adapt as needed; we can’t take anything as certain when facing off with one of our own.”

“Any risk of capes?” Whisperwind was a slender woman with a soft demeanor, yet her voice carried well every time she chose to speak.

“With as many lookout teams as we’ve got stationed, there better not be,” Stasis said. “The fewer bodies to keep track of, the more likely we are to get him this time, so we’ve got three separate lines of security. Short of the major players, if one does wander by, we’ll at least have warning.”

Onslaught’s sizable form leaned down, a habit of trying to speak to others on roughly their same level. “At least it’s not a Ridge City base. Hiding all the way out in Ebnerville, he *really* didn’t want us to find him. Endless Blitz loved living in the big city.”

“The remote location and small amount of overall crime make it low priority for capes,” Morgana noted. “Which will aid our own efforts, as well. In a way, perhaps we should be thankful to Endless Blitz. It was so considerate of him to set the scene out where no one will hear his screams.”

The room nodded along with her, some even smiling at the sentiment. It was arguable how deep into true evil the various members of the guild fell, but there was certainly a moral gradient at play. On the subject of revenge, however, they were a far more unified group. This guild was more than just a loose association of crooks; it was a symbol of their collective power and pride—one that Endless Blitz had spit upon when he betrayed them, sealing his fate in the process. To wrong a villain was to court death.

To wrong a guild of them, well, that was essentially getting onto death’s lap and grinding hard. If Endless Blitz was so desperate to face his end, then as his former friends, they would oblige this final request.



Setting the controller down, Donald leaned back, the look of satisfaction on his face reflected back in the dark TV. The phantom Donald vanished as a fresh screen appeared, displaying the upgrade options he'd just unlocked. With planned ease, he checked off the selections, watching as the parts spun onto his digital jetpack, replacing the older versions to create a stable, quick flight system.

This was his secondary project of the week. The first, and far more taxing one, had been dealing with the New Science Sentries as his team's shadow. They were polite, thankfully, though he suspected that to be largely the product of Agent Quantum's influence. To their credit, the team did excellent work. There had been a few occasions where they'd needed the extra numbers to take a call, and things had gone smoothly overall. It had also been during those moments that Donald began to grow a hunch about the team's primary issue.

While he hadn't felt confident enough to voice the notion yet, there did seem to be a fundamental philosophical difference in the foundation of their training. Apollo, for all the bad he did, had taught new capes the AHC protocols, one of the most important of which was that the goal was saving civilians. Sometimes, that meant taking down the threat, but it could also mean getting people clear, or shielding them from fallout.

From what he'd seen of the New Science Sentries, their education appeared to focus on threat neutralization first and foremost. They came in swinging and didn't stop until everyone was down. It wasn't wrong, necessarily. Their team was still protecting people, helping to make the world better. Yet there was something about it that felt... wrong. Without being able to put a finger on why, Donald just knew that their apparent enthusiasm for combat left a bad taste in his mouth. He suspected that feeling to be a large part of why they weren't clicking in Ridge City. The people understood what standards capes were supposed to uphold and could tell when something was off. It wasn't so bad now that he'd talked with Agent Quantum and knew that they were trying to improve, but the rest of the world didn't have the benefit of that perspective.

They had been getting better: on Thursday's outing there'd only been one broken bone, and Agent Quantum had tried to take the mugger down less forcefully first. Still, Donald was glad they didn't have any actual patrols scheduled for that evening. He could use a break, and with his

newest tool finally ready for testing, this was a perfect chance to go put it through its paces.

Scooping up his phone from the bed, Donald clicked on Ren's name, the number connecting quickly. "Hey. No, don't worry, no schedule change. We're still free today. That's why I was calling actually—you up for some fun tonight? I wanted to test out my jetpack. Oh hell no. Not in Ridge City; way too many tall buildings and other metas zipping around for a test flight. I was thinking somewhere more isolated, where I'd have room for mistakes."

Glancing down at the GPS on his phone, Donald scrolled over the map, hunting for a city big enough to explore, but without too many obstacles. "How about Ebnerville, up near the Canadian border? Pretty sure the AHC can jump us there, and I doubt there'll be much for me to hit, aside from trees. I'll double-check and let you know."

One press of the button, and the call was done. Donald zoomed in on the map, taking a closer look at his potential selection. While the notion had been spur of the moment, Ebnerville seemed as good an option as any. Testing the jetpack was what sincerely excited him. Making a mental note to go be sure they had viable transportation available, he turned his attention back to the screen and the newly completed item spinning around on the display.

Blue energy crackled along his fingertips as Donald reached for the code inside the computer resting in his skull. If he was taking it out for a test drive tonight, he'd best familiarize himself with the jetpack's controls.



With the hiss of a helmet locking into place, Tori vanished.

Hephaestus cycled through her various system startups, then took a tentative step forward. Not perfect—there was still a noticeable difference between moving like this versus on her own—but the gap was shrinking. A few more rounds of fine-tuning and she'd have it: fluid, seamless motion, like there was no extra weight on her at all. She could practically feel it. Those tuning rounds would have to wait for Tori, however, as Hephaestus had a full evening ahead.

Stepping out into the guild's hallway, she found Bahamut waiting; clad in her armored outfit and transformed to green dragon form. They fell into step alongside one another, heading toward the transportation chamber. While they could hop from the island to Ridge City using the installed gate, getting elsewhere still required special assistance. Whoever was putting this together had tapped the pair named Tunnel Vision to bring over all the teams. Theirs would be among the last to go out; the attacking units were already on the ground, getting prepared.

Arriving in the wide, open room with a vast, unmarked back wall, Hephaestus noted Pest Control in the corner, talking with Glyph. The former was clad in his almost beekeeper-like outfit, a costume with various metal rings adorning the exterior. As for Glyph, he'd made a few ensemble changes since they last saw him in costume. The cloak was traded for a stylized jacket, and his robe had been tailored up substantially to allow for easier movement. He still wielded the same wand, though Hephaestus couldn't fault him for that. Considering that the wand not only allowed him to draw his namesake symbols wherever they were needed but also stored a prepared glyph ready to be deployed, it was a crucial piece of his outfit. Even being a gift from Balaam, it was too useful a tool to discard, not something that could be easily cast aside out of mere dark sentiment.

At their arrival, Pest Control looked up, waving them over to join. "Good timing! Tunnel Vision finished the last team a few minutes ago, so we can go as soon as you're ready. Anyone have additional questions or issues to go over?" It had been a little odd, seeing Pest Control take the lead on this job, but he'd proven to be unexpectedly adept at it. Not the actual planning part so much—there had been a few key tweaks needed to his original layout—rather, Pest Control led well because he did a good job of taking input from others. When they brought up issues, they were dealt with, rather than brushed aside for not fitting Pest Control's vision. While Hephaestus was relatively new to all of this, Tori had witnessed far worse leadership styles than that.

"I feel solid." Hephaestus clanged her chest, producing a dense ring that briefly drifted through the air. The more she wore the suit, the more natural the movements felt. "Got my position and my job. Fly high, keep my profile low. Scan for any potential issues before they get close enough to surprise us."

“If they do get close and they’re human, leave them to me,” Pest Control reiterated. “Between my meta-insects and some entomological expeditions, I’ve got a bug for just about every problem. Every problem without special abilities, that is.”

The sound of scales scraping registered as Bahamut slammed a meaty fist into her open palm. Not even her size betrayed just how strong the dragon’s arms really were. Bahamut wasn’t nearly the mightiest of their guild, but her punches would hurt most opponents nevertheless. “Metas who get close, on the other hand, are for me and Glyph.”

“I do have a few new etchings I’m ready to try out.” Tapping his wand, a look dashed across Glyph’s face, one of sudden realization and swift embarrassment. “Almost forgot to tell you both. Just to be safe, I prepared an emergency escape spell as the symbol loaded in my wand. No way I want to get penned in like at the museum again. If anything gets too bad, group up around me when I give the signal.”

The sound of approach drew Hephaestus’s attention. She quickly realized the synchronized steps belonged to Tunnel Vision, a team of teleportation-empowered siblings. She was never quite sure which was which, or even if the names were meant to be separated. Since the two functioned in tandem, it was an academic concern. Nevertheless, her natural curiosity refused to let the point lay entirely.

In less than a minute, the pair had torn a hole through space itself, offering a portal that appeared to look out onto an old logging camp, one that had long ago been abandoned. Hephaestus knew the location already from Pest Control’s plan. This was their entry and exit point, a location far enough from the action to not be noticed, but close enough to run for if needed.

Together with her team, they stepped from the guild’s volcano lair into Ebnerville, site of what was supposed to be a few hours’ simple lookout work for a hefty payday. Hephaestus dialed up her scanners as they walked through, hunting for any single thing that would trip her suspicion. She might be a new villain, but had already seen enough to know few things ever went as easily as they were planned.

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## Chapter 59

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Ebnerville was a city largely in a technical sense. There were adequate facilities and population to claim the title, but those from any actual metropolis would call the town a hamlet, at best. It favored sprawl more than height, meaning there weren't many tall buildings, and certainly no true skyscrapers for Cyber Geek to avoid as he banked hard to the left, gaining a feel for the turn radius he was working with. There would be ways to refine the jetpack further—he had plenty left before he fully completed *Rocket Rangers*—but this was essentially the model he'd be working with going forward. Getting used to it now would only make his usage smoother as the item improved.

Blasting along, Cyber Geek tried to keep parallel with a tree line near the edge of the city. Ebnerville quickly gave way to wilderness once one wandered away from the lights; in the distance, he could see the larger, looming forest massed up like an unmoving army, waiting for the signal to strike. It was a strange sight. Most of his work with the AHC had been in either Ridge City itself or other heavily developed areas, as those tended to have the highest levels of crime. Out here, it was almost serene, ignoring the dull roar of the jetpack. There was a reason he'd gotten the upgrades to quiet the noise; he'd be waking every house he flew past or going deaf from sound exposure otherwise —though Cyber Geek suspected he'd still be in for a headache when all was said and done.

“Looking good. Now bring it around.” Medley was seated on the rooftop of a five-story apartment complex, keeping watch from one of the higher points they could find. In the event someone else did fly through, or

there was an obstacle Cyber Geek seemed on course to collide with, Medley would radio in. With senses as sharp as his, it would be tough for anything to take them by surprise.

Obedying the directions, Cyber Geek extended the turn, circling back so he was headed toward Medley once more. He was slowly starting to get comfortable in the air, though he did keep a constant watch on the jetpack's fuel gauge. After this many upgrades, it would take quite a while to run dry at these speeds, but that was not a limit Cyber Geek wanted to test. He'd fallen from a fourth-floor balcony in a set of item-armor and still bruised his entire back. From this height, the injury would be far more severe.

As he looked up to the night sky, admiring the better view of the stars provided to those who settled farther from civilization, a flash caught Cyber Geek's eye. He wasn't entirely sure what it was, but his training kicked in almost before he'd made a conscious decision. Something was off, and he was a superhero; that made it his job to ensure everyone was safe.

"I caught sight of something just now. Toward the western edge of town. Could have been a rogue firework, maybe. I only caught it for a flash."

On the roof, Medley rose, shaking a touch of evening moisture from his fur. "I'll come, anyway. Better than sitting, and you still need a spotter."

"Not going to argue that point after less than ten minutes of practice," Cyber Geek agreed. "Don't worry, I'm pretty sure I can slow down for you."

"Slow down? I was going to say this is finally *your* chance to be able to keep up." Without any additional warning, Medley took off for the edge of his building in a dash, leaping and easily clearing the divide. Claws sank into the next rooftop for purchase, then immediately released as he took off again, racing for the next roof.

Cyber Geek watched him for a moment, in awe of the strength and grace his friend was displaying. This was miles from the unsure, awkwardly moving version of him that they'd known after the initial change. The more accustomed to the body Medley became, the more dangerous he grew. That was an arrangement Cyber Geek would have been quite happy with, except for the fact it stuck his friend in the body of an animal hybrid. Had there been a cure, a chance for him to be fully Ren again, he wouldn't have blamed Medley for taking it. Until that option arrived, however, he was grateful to have him as a teammate, and a friend.

It also didn't hurt that Medley hadn't been kidding; he really was cutting a furious pace. Adjusting his angle to properly lead the way, Cyber Geek slightly increased the speed of his jetpack. Time to see what this thing could actually do.



“All quiet to the north.”

“Of course it's quiet to the north. There's nothing that way but wolves and trees.” Bahamut's annoyance was steadily rising as the night wore on, which was understandable given her situation. She was currently cramped into a doorframe down a dark alleyway, one of the few places that could effectively hide her sizable green form while still being in a central position. Getting her in had been an ordeal, and the tight quarters were fast eroding her spirits. If someone did wander through, they were going to get one wrathful dragon for their troubles.

“Still quiet,” Hephaestus reiterated, perhaps suppressing a snicker at her friend's momentary, but humorous, misfortune. For her part, she was on the roof of a cracker factory, one of the few high points Ebnerville really had to offer. Southwest of them, deeper into the industrial district, the plan was being carried out. Hephaestus still didn't know what it was, and the deeper in they got, the happier she was about that. The guild was treating this with gravity, and that made it way above anything she wanted to be involved in. Guard duty was more than enough.

A blip in her visor alerted her to the flare of energy just as it spiked into the night sky. The flash was brief. Whoever made it was either aware enough not to make a scene, or had been cut down before they properly could. “Anyone else catch that?”

“Catch what?” Glyph's answer was genuinely interested, a sharp contrast to Bahamut's reply:

“Nope, still just brick and alley—the only things I *can* see.”

Pest Control, thankfully, confirmed Hephaestus's sighting. “A few of my bugs saw that, too. It's blocked by a lot of the other buildings between. Anyone not elevated when it went off probably didn't notice.”

That should have been more reassuring, considering the layout of Ebnerville and the relatively low number of active metas. They barely had



any street-level capes trying to make a name for themselves, let alone ones patrolling the skies. Nevertheless, the pessimist in Hephaestus refused to trust in those odds. She began scanning more actively, searching for any potential threats.

For roughly three minutes, she kept at it, her heightened concern slowly dissipating. Just when she was about to give the all-clear, another blip caught her attention. Heat signature, approaching from the east. Quickly spinning her head, she activated the lens's zoom, pinpointing the source of the heat. A jetpack. Of course, it was someone in a jetpack. As the image sharpened, Hephaestus felt a sudden weight slam into her stomach.

"Shit. We've got a cape approaching." A cape in a costume she recognized quite well. Hephaestus may be too new to have allies, but Tori had kept up with this friend's career. "Cyber Geek, zipping over using a new flying item."

The silence in her ear stretched on, finally broken by Pest Control. "We have to stop him. For his sake as much as the job. Whatever is going on, it's expected to be a bloodbath. We've got councilors fighting. A new cape wandering into that... even if our people try not to hurt him in the chaos, the other side won't have that concern."

They didn't have long to talk about it. Cyber Geek was cutting a solid pace. A leaping form caught Hephaestus's eye; Medley was along for the ride, because apparently, nothing was going to go right tonight. "Update: add Medley to that equation, too."

"Crap. If it was just one, he might be smart enough to steer clear. With backup, it gets riskier." Glyph paused, pondering a notion. "Pest Control and I have something of a working relationship with these two after the riots. If we go out there, they might be willing to listen."

"To what?" Bahamut asked. "That there's a crime going on nearby, but we'd really appreciate it if they hung back and didn't radio anything in? I don't see any cape going for that, working relationship or not."

That wasn't even touching on the fact that it depended on Cyber Geek and Medley being willing to listen, which was far from guaranteed out here in the field. They needed a plan that didn't require talking, a way to lead them away instantly, something they couldn't resist.

Unfortunately, Hephaestus knew exactly what would work. She'd wanted to get in some flying practice, anyway; this functioned as well as

any other occasion. “Bahamut is right. We can’t count on diplomacy for this. We have to trust something more dependable: spite.”

“Don’t even think about it.” Bahamut was already ahead of her, probably trying to wriggle free from her alcove at that very moment.

“You really think it will work?” Pest Control asked, keeping his head on the mission as a whole.

Hephaestus’s mind flashed back to the sight of a smoldering Medley, to the look in his eyes as she was flown out of reach. “I lit the guy on fire and escaped from their clutches. Pretty sure they’ll chase me, given the opportunity. And if they don’t, I’ll just have to encourage them.”

Flight systems were operational; she’d kept them on standby while waiting, just in case. Lifting off her perch, Hephaestus rose through the air, gravity’s grip on her heft knocked back by the technology hidden amidst her suit’s dark depths. She momentarily disabled her sound-suppressing system and blazed into the air, engines roaring. For this to work, she needed to be both seen and heard. More than that, she needed to be recognized.

Staying low until she was away from the others, Hephaestus took a sharp turn skyward as she came closer to Cyber Geek. She rose steadily higher, the brilliant flames bursting out, propelling her forward as she seared the night. There would be no way for him to miss her, even with the suit’s stealth-friendly coloring.

In fact, it ended up being more effective than planned. Due to a bit of poor timing, Hephaestus’s trajectory was slightly off. That meant, instead of rising up before him like an ascending demon, she very nearly collided with the cape, both of them having to spin off in other directions to avoid a crash. She righted herself almost immediately, whereas Cyber Geek nearly went into a spiral, managing to gain control only seconds before Hephaestus might have felt the draw to help.

On a nearby roof, Medley was screaming, and while she didn’t care enough to isolate the sounds, she could more or less put the gist together. He definitely recognized her. The question was, would it be enough?

Hephaestus watched as Cyber Geek reoriented, letting out a small sigh of relief when he pointed himself in her direction, exactly opposite that of the site she was guarding. It worked. The capes were giving chase.

That thought was at least some comfort as Hephaestus blasted further up into the sky with no idea what to do with the capes now that she’d managed to attract them.



Agent Quantum carefully applied the handcuffs, taking pains not to break the suspect's wrists. It wasn't an issue that had come up before, but working with Cyber Geek's team had shed a lot of light on just how strong they were compared to a lot of the criminals they put away. If those slip-ups did happen, it reflected back on the AHC, and capes as a whole. That knowledge had added a layer of caution to every movement these last few days, and even with the week of shadowing over, he wanted to keep those lessons in practice. If they didn't improve, then what was the point of that effort in the first place?

Watching the police lead his latest efforts into a waiting car, Agent Quantum opened up his communication lines, checking in to the AHC's central hub. "Hey, team. New Science Sentries reporting assignment completion. What's the next thing we can help with?"

The voices always changed—running an operation of the AHC's size required a sizable staff—but their readiness was constant. He'd barely finished before a voice was providing answers. "We've got nothing but some minor security alarms reported near your current position—probably going to be due for another jump to get to the action. Hope you had fun in California."

It was a trite joke that got used every time capes were spirited off to a destination location, only to then spend their time working. Agent Quantum offered up a polite laugh; this too was part of the job, in its way.

"Let's see... if we're jumping you anyway, looks like Cyber Geek just called in something suspicious. Potential wanted criminal spotted out in Ebnerville. Not a high priority, but since you've been working together, I thought I'd offer."

The issue didn't sound especially pressing; then again, it also didn't seem like there were any major emergencies to tackle anywhere else at the moment. After letting them tag along for a week, the very least his team could do was make sure Cyber Geek didn't need any assistance. On the off chance he did, all the better. It would be a chance to show their thanks for the help he'd provided.

"Get me a jump to Cyber Geek's position as soon as someone is available. Looks like the New Science Sentries are visiting Ebnerville."

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## Chapter 60

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The longer a chase went on, the worse it was for the one being pursued. A cape could call in more help, additional surveillance, whatever they needed to lock down their target. Generally speaking, Hephaestus's strategy would have been to speed up and start weaving through the trees, losing her pursuers in the confusion and then sneaking away. The trouble was that she *had* to stay visible for this to work. If escape was out, and continued pursuit put the odds against her, then that meant Hephaestus needed another idea. It took almost two minutes of racing through the skies, but eventually, she hit upon a solution.

She'd been approaching the issue as a criminal, when this was actually a villain's job.

Decreasing her speed, Hephaestus began the process of descent. The area she'd selected was well off from the battle site—also relatively deserted at this time of night. A strip mall, filled with discount shops and chain eateries, all darkened and empty. The closest thing to other human life was a large cutout of Flex Force showing off in a nutrient shop's window. No civilians to get involved if things took a turn for the messy.

Dropping low, she landed roughly, leaving a scorch mark on the cement. That part would take more practice; had this been grass, she might have accidentally started a fire. With a quick mental note to tweak the landing systems, she scanned the sky for her pursuers. Cyber Geek wasn't far behind, though Medley flagged slightly farther back as his rooftop options ran short.

The jetpack didn't leave any signs or scorches as Cyber Geek set down, attention already trained on Hephaestus. Show-off. Before he could speak, she yelled at him, the suit's voice modulator masking her true identity.

"What do you fucking want? I waved sorry about the near miss, yet you still felt the need to follow me? I've got video recording and 911 on speed dial, so take a few steps back. Getting some real creep vibes off of you."

It took Cyber Geek back for a moment. He'd been expecting her to take the role of the aggressor. "I... I know who you are."

"Really? You don't ring a bell for me. Sure it wasn't someone else with an experimental meta-suit?" Hephaestus saw the flicker of uncertainty in Cyber Geek's eyes. While the aesthetic was the same, this suit had undeniable differences since the reworking. Enough to cause doubt, and that was what she needed more than anything: make him unsure, keep them off-balance, and stall like hell until the coast was clear.

That was when Medley finally closed the gap. His tongue hung slightly off to the side as he ran, darting back inside his mouth just as it was time to speak. "Hephaestus! Surrender now, and we can do this peacefully."

"Who the hell is Hephaestus?" Hephaestus demanded. "I know there was a cape named Red Hephaestus a while back, but I think he's been dead for a long time."

Medley wasn't so easily knocked off-kilter. He continued to approach, clearly ready for battle. "What a lazy attempt at trickery. Do you really expect it to work?" Every muscle was taut. He shook out his limbs, readying them for rapid movement. She remembered how strong that body was; if Medley hit, it was going to hurt.

"Here's a better question: do you realize what you're about to do? Right now, I'm a civilian in a meta-suit. You have established no criminal identity, no active crime in progress, and no outstanding warrants. That flexing you're doing—that's not for a fight. It's for assault, and my video recording is going to show exactly that."

Hephaestus tapped her helmet, a keen reminder to everyone present that she was coated from head-to-toe in electronics. Medley's eager pace suddenly halted, the reality of her words sinking in. A criminal was bound by the system, while a villain knew how to turn that system right back against the capes who trusted it.

"On the chance this is a misunderstanding, you have our apologies. However, your suit bears striking similarities to the type used by a creator

named Hephaestus, who is wanted for questioning in connection to a museum robbery.” Cyber Geek had recovered just as Medley lost his stride. The two made a good team. Under different circumstances, she’d have been glad to see them covering one another so well.

“Cool story. Got a warrant and some cops to go with it?” Hephaestus demanded. “Because last I checked, the Alliance of Heroic Champions aided law enforcement, without actually being such an entity itself. That clears you of a lot of liability, sure, but it also means that unless you have an actual warrant in hand or I’m presenting a provable, active danger, you can go get fucked. So, I ask again: got any paperwork and law enforcement shoved up that spandex ass? Remember, you’re being filmed.”

This was not the way Cyber Geek and Medley had expected the encounter to play out. They were accustomed to dealing with crooks who would scream and flee, or jump right into combat. She couldn’t imagine anyone they’d dealt with prior had attempted to use technicalities as their weapon of choice.

Finally, Cyber Geek found his answer. “No, I don’t have a warrant to arrest you. Instead, I’ll be happy to call the local PD and have them come take you into custody for questioning, while Medley and I wait here to keep you company.”

Though the clangs were loud as Hephaestus began to tick points off on her fingers, she kept up the theatrics all the same. The less concerned she appeared to be by these two, the more they’d worry she truly had nothing to fear. “Keep me here without my consent—that’s kidnapping. Follow me without cause, harassment. Try following me from a distance, without my knowledge, and I bet we can slip a few breach-of-privacy charges onto the harassment, maybe even a sex crime if I stop to piss and you both sneak a peek.”

Cyber Geek actually got a touch rosy in the cheeks at that one, though Medley was looking more and more furious by the second. He knew it was bullshit. They *all* knew it was bullshit. The question was how much could any person present prove it. Her suit had changed, enough to have reasonable doubt, and if flying homemade creations around were illegal, then a big chunk of the airborne capes would already be in jail. She’d stymied the pair without a single punch being thrown. There was a chance she owed Ivan an apology—all that harping on the code and learning the specifics had turned out more useful than she anticipated.

Most capes, she suspected, would have let it go at that. She'd made too much trouble, and presented a strong case. Trying to keep pushing just opened up more problems than it fixed, all for the cape who made the play. Trouble was, Cyber Geek could show an unexpectedly heroic spirit when put against a wall.

"I can live with that. If you're proven innocent and would like to press charges against me, then I'll give a full confession to every part of this interaction. Kidnapping seems like a reach, but I'm sure there will be consequences. Consequences I'd much rather live with than with the knowledge that I let a dangerous criminal escape justice." Cyber Geek started forward, and he didn't look like he'd be so easy to derail this time.

Time for a reassessment. Without knowing for sure what was happening at the battle, she couldn't risk turning these two loose. Going to jail, on the other hand, also wasn't on the table. Her only option left was to buy as much time as possible, and then run for it. She could always ditch the suit and make her escape as Tori, picking it up when the coast was clear. No matter how she sliced it, however, there were slim odds she'd be able to keep this delay rolling without things getting a bit messy.

"Seeing as you're attempting unlawful restraint, I hope you realize I'm in my rights to fight back, cape or not." Hephaestus made sure power was flowing into her blaster gauntlets, and that the setting was low. She didn't want to hurt them badly, but couldn't very well risk losing the fight either.

"Finally. I wondered when I'd get my rematch." Medley bounded forward, though Hephaestus noted his claws weren't extended yet. Despite the tough talk, he was playing it as a cape, coming in softly first, to be safe.

Hephaestus held no such compunctions, and had the benefit of knowing Medley to be incredibly resilient. As he leaped, arms wide for some sort of hug-clutch, she fired a beam directly into his knee, sending him spinning back through the air with a screaming yowl.

"What did you do?" That was the only line Cyber Geek got out before the cold metal of Hephaestus's elbow smashed into the bridge of his nose. He'd made the mistake of watching Medley's fall, rather than keeping an eye on the enemy, and was quickly taught the error of his ways. The nose broke instantly, sending tears to his eyes and blood pouring down the front of his face. It was fortunate he didn't wear a mask, or it would have been soaked in seconds.

“Fought back.” Hephaestus didn’t press the assault as she watched the blood drip. In truth, she’d expected Cyber Geek to dodge; it hadn’t exactly been the most efficient blow. The shock of seeing her friend in pain caused her to pause, a sudden flash of loyalty arriving at the most inconvenient of times. The cold, logical side of her mind swept into action, rationalizing at lightning speeds. It reminded her that a nose wasn’t so bad, more pain than anything, and the AHC had the resources to replace entire limbs. This wouldn’t be more than a blip in the long term, no matter how painful it felt for the moment. Whereas, if she was caught, the consequences would be far more long-lasting.

Scratching reached her ears as Medley drew himself back up, tenderly putting a reduced amount of weight on his still-smoking knee. At full force, that beam of energy could have carved through the bone. This was little more than a flesh wound in comparison. A flesh wound that still slowed Medley down—a benefit Hephaestus would gladly accept. After their last battle, when she’d been a slow-moving hunk and he’d easily overpowered her, it felt good to show she wasn’t a threat to be taken lightly.

“Think we’d have to land a hit for it to be fighting back.” Medley fell onto all fours, compensating for his injured limb. His tail rose high, ready to strike as he dashed along the ground. Hephaestus fired, only for him to swerve to the side, nimbly missing the shot. Hephaestus shot twice more, each time the blasts were avoided by Medley.

The fourth shot, he dodged as well. It was the fifth, fired right after the fourth, from Hephaestus’s other gauntlet, that finally found home. Unaware that she had multiple weapons, Medley wasn’t quite prepared to react post-dodge, earning a shot to the flank that burned away a section of his fur. He clutched his ribs as he rolled along the concrete.

Sparkling blue light drew Hephaestus back to Cyber Geek. He was reaching into the code for a weapon, something he *should* have done before getting into combat. Hopefully, he’d learn from this mistake; his next opponent probably wouldn’t be inclined to go easy. To that point, Hephaestus raised a blaster and fired a single shot into Cyber Geek’s left foot, again at the lowest setting. He still screeched, perhaps from surprise as much as pain. The blue light flared out as his concentration faltered, leaving him exposed while Hephaestus darted over.

She hadn’t actually expected the fight to go so well; having the advantage of surprise made a huge difference. They might have seen her



there, but neither expected her to come out swinging for the fences. Such was the trouble with gradually sliding up the power scale to deal with new threats: those threats had no such obligation to play by the same rules.

“If you two are done, can I go back to flying around peacefully? Seems like you could probably use some more practice at all of this, anyway. I can even—”

An entirely new sensation came over Hephaestus, like someone was trying to tear her out from within her suit. Instantly, she fully shifted to fire form, yet the pull didn’t dissipate. It expanded out, yanking on Hephaestus as a whole, and for a moment, it felt like she might not fit into whatever cosmic hole was being formed. Then, like a champagne cork, she popped through space itself, her mind momentarily boggled at seeing existence from the inside out, only to appear again across the strip mall.

It wasn’t where she was that was relevant, so much as what—or rather, who—she was in front of. The punch from Agent Quantum lit up several alarms on her sensors, and the super-speed kick from Tachyonic less than a second later only compounded the problem. Had she been flesh, the rapid shift in momentum would have had the emergency vomit protocols fully activated. Instead, she just put everything she had into staying upright.

Set before her were the New Science Sentries, only, for the first time, she wasn’t seeing them as a civilian being rescued or a neighbor being pestered. As their adversary, she looked into the hard, battle-ready looks in their eyes, and suddenly found herself quite nostalgic for those bothersome neighbors. Because in the field, with combat upon them, the New Science Sentries looked downright terrifying.

And she was the focal point of all their attention.

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## Chapter 61

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“Armor Boy there has got more heft than he lets on. Not an easy one to move, and he’s slippery inside.” Presto appeared safely out of harm’s reach, which explained how Hephaestus had been moved into such an inopportune position.

Although she hadn’t collapsed, her suit was blaring with alerts. In just two blows, the New Science Sentries had managed extensive damage to her shell. With attacks like that, it was only a matter of time before they broke something vital. This was not a fight she wanted, if it could be possibly helped.

“Oh good, more enforcers from the AHC here to help their friends with kidnapping. Guess after you so spectacularly failed to prevent one, aiding the kidnappers is the next logical step.”

It was, admittedly, a low blow, though if anyone had the right to throw that punch, it was the woman who’d endured the actual incident. Her hope was that it would rattle the New Science Sentries, giving them momentary pause to consider their role in the current situation. Instead, she received a brief proximity alert before Tachyonic slammed into her back, sending her spinning through the air with the force of his accelerated momentum.

She landed face up, starting to rise only to find Tachyonic crouched over her, his face inches from her helmet. “Don’t even fucking try it after that line. Agent Quantum, could you help me with restraint? Plasmodia, if you don’t mind, I think we need a can opener.”

From the left of Agent Quantum, Plasmodia stepped into view, her beauty turned terrifying in the flickering light of the energy spike extended

from her right hand. Tough as Hephaestus's suit was, that thing would definitely carve through it; she'd seen the kind of power Plasmodia could conjure. On instinct, she started to move, only to find one of Tachyonic's hands suddenly resting on her shoulder.

"No matter what you do, it'll be too slow. Struggle all you like. We're taking you in."

A new noise came from behind Hephaestus: Cyber Geek's voice calling to the other capes. Thanks to using microphones rather than primitive eardrums, she was able to make out the words despite the distance.

"Watch out!"

Evidently, Agent Quantum had also been blessed with enhanced hearing, as he waved back to Cyber Geek. "Don't worry. We've got him. Might have a lot to learn in some respects, but fighting is one part of the job we can—"

His boast was cut off by several hundred pounds of green dragon flesh slamming into his back fist-first, adding the momentum of a skyward fall to the blow. Despite not seeing the approach, Hephaestus could put it together, especially given the patches of white scales still fading on Bahamut's form. She'd flown after Hephaestus, saw the trouble, and had dropped right in to help. It was an unexpected opportunity, one they had to use to the fullest.

For a brief, wonderful moment, the entire New Science Sentries team was stunned: Agent Quantum by the punch, everyone else from seeing their leader get knocked on his ass. While they were distracted, Hephaestus struck. A single punch wouldn't do much, especially given the rate at which super-speed aided healing. Taking Tachyonic out of the fight wasn't about injuring him; it was about making him ineffective.

To most people in her situation, the only recourse would be simple battle; however, Hephaestus was more than the might of her suit. She also had the brain of an inventor, one who took note of design details: a bracer getting touched frequently during combat, or the special containment material composing a costume. Tachyonic was hiding a secret—which was to say, a vulnerability.

Between the way she'd seen him occasionally tap that silver bracer on his right arm and the energy output signature her scanners were registering, Hephaestus had something of a hunch. Tachyonic might have super-speed on his own, but it certainly appeared as if he was augmenting that power out in the field. His suit was emitting trace amounts of setlium radiation, a

telltale sign that he was dosing his cells in the meta-element. That level of tech was certainly in the realm of Professor Quantum to dream up; however, the implementation was a touch crude. After all, external controls presented a major vulnerability, especially against enemies who knew what to look for.

In the flash of distraction, Hephaestus struck, wrapping her right gauntlet around Tachyonic's bracer. Blasting would destroy it, along with Tachyonic's arm, which felt like a step too far, even in straights so dire. Instead, she funneled power into the mechanical muscles of the machine, squeezing for all she was worth. The bracer was well made. She was going to burn out half the motors in her hand, and would replace each with a smile on her face if it got her and Bahamut out of here.

"You brought frie—what the hell!" Tachyonic spun back around just as his bracer cracked, emitting a series of sparks and hisses. He tried to grab at the device, but bursts of electricity burned his hand at every attempt. "Come on... stabilize..."

The New Science Sentries were already recovering, Presto raising a hand to Bahamut as Plasmodia built power for a blast that would injure, if not cripple, even the green dragon. With no time to think, Hephaestus went on the attack. Rather than give Tachyonic time to stabilize, she cracked him in the nose with her elbow—the same offensive Cyber Geek had received to equally similar results. Either too unstable or too distracted to notice the incoming blow, Tachyonic took it full force, stumbling backward. In his case, something of a rueful expression peeked out through the mask, at least for the brief moment he had before Hephaestus shoved Tachyonic directly into Presto.

Both went down in a tangle, which should have given Hephaestus the chance to take out Plasmodia. Unfortunately, she'd made the mistake of forgetting what had brought her to this strip mall in the first place. Medley had finally recovered, and the sound of his panting approach gave her warning just before the slashing claws tried to part her armor. She slipped back, and he stayed close, not giving her any opportunity to switch back to ranged.

"Like I was saying—finally, a rematch." He smiled, she thought; it wasn't easy to tell given the animalistic structure of his face.

Glancing to the side, she saw Agent Quantum rising to his feet once more, with Plasmodia nearby to help. Farther back, she could make out the

familiar blue flicker of Cyber Geek grabbing an item. Odds were steeply against them, and only getting worse.

If not for the buzzing of insect wings, Hephaestus might have lost hope. She could hear them, though, and that meant Pest Control wasn't far off. Whatever the plan might be—if there even was one—she had no clue. The best Hephaestus could manage was to stay free and uninjured while helping her friends do the same. Glyph had their emergency escape option, assuming they could reach him.

Medley came in swinging again, claws and tail flowing naturally. He'd been training, yet it was more than that. This was like he'd been learning to fight specifically using these weapons. Did the AHC offer some sort of inhuman martial arts program for people like Medley? Whatever the cause, Hephaestus was suitably impressed by his improvement, even as she deflected his attacks.

Capes weren't the only ones who got to grow after wins and losses, however. Compared to the last time they met, Hephaestus was markedly faster, stronger, and tougher, thanks to the various design upgrades. Her improved movement was showing the most benefits of all, as Hephaestus was able to somewhat keep pace with the furious flurry of attacks.

The ranged shot to her knee, unfortunately, slowed Hephaestus down. She could see Cyber Geek crouched at a distance, that comically huge video game gun propped up and taking aim once more. To her shock, Medley swung, and then leapt aside, giving Cyber Geek a perfect window. Hephaestus only just barely managed to dodge a second shot to the leg. This wasn't just some makeshift tactic on the fly; they'd trained this way, with Cyber Geek sniping as Medley wore the enemy down.

On the upside, he was still a cape, which meant the shot had been intended to wound rather than annihilate. Though Hephaestus wouldn't be completing any marathons until after the repairs, she could stay standing, for however much good that did. At that thought, another notion popped into mind. Why was she bothering with her legs at all? Landing had been essential to deal with Cyber Geek and Medley, but they were well past that point.

Using the momentary space Medley had so graciously provided, Hephaestus fired up her jets and shot into the sky, earning an angry yowl as he attempted an ineffectual pounce. From here, she could see the battlefield more effectively. Bahamut and Agent Quantum resembled prizefighters,

exchanging punches like pleasantries at a church social. Plasmodia hung near the edge, ready to help; however, the tight confines of the fight limited her ability to shoot. Tachyonic and Presto were working on untangling themselves, hindered by Tachyonic suddenly speeding up and slowing down at inopportune moments. Medley was yowling, Cyber Geek was taking aim, and on top of the strip mall, Hephaestus could see what she'd been hoping for.

A mass of buzzing and wings swirled as Pest Control summoned more and more insects: some meta, some mundane, all of them annoying. Since Glyph was at his side, Hephaestus could take a general guess as to what the plan was. Get the bugs to critical mass, drop a bomb of confusion on the battlefield, and that was their window to escape. She and Bahamut would both have to make it onto the roof—not an easy task in their current situation.

The shot blazing past her visor reminded Hephaestus that Cyber Geek wasn't going to aim forever; eventually, he'd pull the trigger. She had to minimize their ranged options for the escape. Plasmodia's power was internal, whereas Cyber Geek's could be taken away.

That made the choice for her. Hephaestus dove, Medley already scrambling to meet her. It was his turn to be too slow, as she took a shot from Cyber Geek in the left shoulder just before landing. Alarms blared, and she was notified that functionality in the arm was reduced by roughly thirty percent. He was getting pretty good with that rifle, stupid size or not.

Since it was so conveniently propped up on the ground, Hephaestus dropped the entirety of her weight and landed directly on the huge barrel. No doubt the fictional gun was meant to withstand a huge amount of damage; however, hundreds of pounds of metal slamming into a section with no support underneath was simply too much physics to be ignored. It snapped clean down the middle, turning back into blue sparks as it dissolved.

"This didn't have to be a fight." Looking down at him, Hephaestus saw something she wasn't prepared for: fear. Cyber Geek was afraid of her, and why not? She'd just injured him, stood momentarily against the New Science Sentries, and had now easily broken his go-to weapon. More interesting than that was that despite the fear he so plainly wore, Cyber Geek's hands were still glowing as he went for more items. Fear be damned. He wasn't giving up.

“Maybe not,” Cyber Geek agreed. “But unless you’re willing to surrender, I don’t see it ending.”

Rather than respond, Hephaestus whirled around, firing a shot from her left gauntlet into Medley’s hip. Sneaking up on her in the middle of battle was one thing; she had no intention of letting him within swinging distance again. By the time she’d turned back, Cyber Geek had manifested a large green wrench with various runes on it.

“It’s called the Wrecking Wrench, from *Clankbur’s Junkyard Journey*. Nowhere near my best building tool, but it does triple damage to anything mechanical to help tear it apart.” Apparently, Medley wasn’t the only one sore over the last time—an item like that had obviously been planned for Hephaestus, or any other person wearing a meta-suit.

A huge explosion tore the night, stealing the attention of everyone in the strip mall parking lot. Further down the street, a car had detonated so aggressively that it flipped over and was now casting light from the roaring flames. Hephaestus might have been confused, save for the buzzing she’d paid such close attention to. It suddenly swelled in volume, her lone warning before the swarm fell upon them. Glyph must have snuck around to set something up, a starter pistol of sorts.

It was like a blanket of bugs covered the entire area. Cursing, swatting, even some yelps rang out as the clear night became hideously obscured. To Hephaestus, it was the sound of sweet escape, as she used the combo of distractions to leap back into the night. Briefly, she feared the bugs would clog her engine, but she quickly broke through them into the clear night air of the sky. Through the swirling insects, she could just make out Agent Quantum trying to chase Bahamut, even as her scales shifted from green to white.

Taking a cue out of Cyber Geek’s tactics, Hephaestus fired off a few blasts, one searing Agent Quantum’s shoulder. While it was nowhere near enough to stop him, the delay gave Bahamut room to escape, and once she’d flapped those white wings past the layer of bugs, Hephaestus set a course for the roof.

A few stray shots from Plasmodia rang out; however, she couldn’t risk shooting any real power blindly, and even the few she dared quickly faded as more shouts came from within the bugs. Hephaestus and Bahamut both slammed down into the roof in short succession, grouping in next to Glyph and a loudly panting Pest Control. Calling up that many bugs in that short

of time must have taken it out of him. They owed him a drink when this was over.

“Please tell me we’re good to go.” In that moment, her greatest fear was a guild order to keep distracting the capes. They’d managed this far thanks largely to surprise, an element of battle that was quickly fading. Much longer, and the whole team was as good as captured.

“Officially cleared. Things are wrapping up, anyway,” Glyph reported, saving Pest Control the effort. “Everyone, get around me, now.”

They all complied, laying hands on Glyph, just to be safe, as he pointed the wand downward and released the stored spell. In flaring purple light, a complex circle formed around all four, composed of runes and symbols Hephaestus had no frame of reference for. Magic was its own thing, and she didn’t have to understand it to be thankful as the spell activated, tearing them all from the strip mall roof in Ebnerville.

Unlike with Presto’s power, this was more akin to the whole world flashing purple, then looking different as a new scene faded into view. They were near Ridge City—Hephaestus could recognize the lights from here—except, given the distance, they had to be at least half an hour’s drive from downtown, if not more.

“With this spell, you have to set the teleportation point in advance,” Glyph explained. He was stepping out of a matching circle to the one they’d left in, only this one was seared into the dirt. “It’s possible to follow if someone had jumped into the circle with us, so I set it out in the middle of nowhere, just to be safe.”

“Good call. Showing up with a cape at the guild would be bad for everyone—most of all the cape,” Hephaestus agreed. “Where to now?”

“Nearest highway is three miles from here. That’s where the guild car will meet us.” Finally somewhat recovered, Pest Control got the words out, albeit breathily.

“We could fly,” Bahamut suggested. She spread her large wings, illustrating the point.

“After tonight, I’m okay with keeping as low a profile as possible. At least until we’re back at the guild.” Hephaestus hitched an arm under Pest Control for support as they began walking down the dirt path.

A few seconds later, Bahamut took the other side with a freshly shifted green arm. In a way, it felt almost like their first training exercise, where Pest Control had crossed the finish line with a broken leg. If only that had



been their night. Giant killer robots were a pain, but outside of surprise sentience, they didn't tend to hold grudges.

Capes, on the other hand, had far better memories, especially for the quarries who slipped away.

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## Chapter 62

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Bloodbath didn't even begin to describe it. Chunks, viscera, tendons, perhaps a rogue finger here and there—those were the largest pieces the forensics team was finding as they combed through what could most accurately be called a cold flesh stew.

Standing above them, watching the proceedings with calculated indifference, Professor Quantum observed as the Ebnerville police worked, aided by several AHC resources. These were helpful for smaller towns not equipped to deal with such catastrophes and were able to respond faster than any government agency could hope to. Of course, since the resources belonged to the Alliance of Heroic Champions, any information uncovered in the aftermath would also flow directly to them. Whatever the cost of this nicety, it had paid for itself thousands of times over already in useful data.

Tonight, he feared, would be an exception to that rule. When he'd heard his team had faced combat, Professor Quantum knew he had to witness the scene. He'd been expecting another move from his unseen adversary, perhaps more merchandise from the past, but merely being a superhero came with its own conflicts. In this case, it hadn't been related to a lingering grudge, or not one aimed toward Professor Quantum, anyway. Worse, this was clearly guild work; the utter lack of evidence confirmed that the longer the scene was searched. Professor Quantum had already suspected as much, once he arrived on scene and got the full debrief.

The suit and dragon were newer recruits; he'd skimmed the files and therefore, his brain could easily recall such details. They'd been linked to the museum heist, which Apollo had conjectured to be a training mission

for new villains. It seemed the training wheels were now off, if they'd been able to last against his team. Some of that might have been to blame on Lodestar and her soft methods. When he'd sent them from Vomisa, they were a fine-tuned battle engine, capable of handling threats even beyond their actual powers. The advocacy of softness had, quite expectedly, weakened them. A necessary sacrifice to keep the AHC at large appeased, but one that he would have to minimize the impact of.

Between the low-level lackeys playing lookout and the absolute decimation on the scene, there was little need to even call this speculation. Someone had wronged the guild, and they'd responded. Were Lodestar here, there would have been hand-wringing for the ones they couldn't save, whereas Professor Quantum didn't especially care. If any of these had the potential to be worthy test subjects, they'd have survived, so it was no great loss.

The larger issue was that the New Science Sentries had taken a defeat. By his standards, if not the AHC's. Such errors were unacceptable, especially considering they'd been facing off with a pair of villain rookies. Between their numbers and training, it should have been effortless. These were not the results he'd invested so much time into that team to reap. They were going to have to step up, and soon; otherwise, he'd be forced to move on to his contingency plans.

A team wasn't set in stone, after all, and there were plenty of other candidates back on Vomisa. If they couldn't pull together, then he'd simply tear the configuration apart and try again, as many times as it took, to create a proper team of successors. He would not allow the name of Science Sentries to be dragged down by their ineptitude. Not after all the work that had gone into establishing it.

Professor Quantum turned away from the scene, hand on his phone, the next task already on his mind.



With the program finally running, Tori fell back into a sitting position, sighing in relief. The walk back to the highway hadn't been a fun one, nor was waiting until the coast was clear to load everyone in to a guild SUV. After that, things got easier. It was just a drive to the country club and a hop

through the portal to get back to the guild's volcano lair and, by extension, her spare room.

Pausing only long enough for a shower, Tori's first task was running diagnostics on the Hephaestus suit. It had taken some finagling to get the laptop cord connected—the port had been slightly warped during the battle—but with the diagnostics now flashing on-screen, Tori could check the damage her creation had sustained. All things considered, it had held up well. However, from what she was already seeing, there weren't a lot of hits left for it to take. Another good shot and something critical might have gone offline. With ease of movement becoming less of an issue, it was time to move on to defense.

While her current suit had been redesigned and tweaked, she'd been using the same base components as much as possible. It was her habit, as a thief and a scrounger, plus it helped to keep the costs in check. Looking over the claw marks Medley had managed to leave in a shoulder plate, it was evident that her armor was in need of an upgrade. Last time, she'd used metals that were high quality, but also mundane. To tangle with metas, the suit had to be able to withstand more damage. Energy shields ate power, most of which she was directing toward mobility and offense. Changing the base material would be the fix that required the least amount of work to keep up, but also the most effort up front. Tori would have to actually invent or steal a meta-alloy to make her suit out of one.

That was a long-term concern; the more immediate issue was getting her suit up and running again. She didn't have plans to take Hephaestus out again anytime soon, yet Tori didn't feel quite right with her armor temporarily out of commission. When it was down, she lacked the choice to be Hephaestus, and that rubbed against her brain wrong for reasons that Tori couldn't fully articulate.

Repairs would be extensive, and also would have to wait for another day. With diagnostics running, she couldn't do much, so Tori departed her room and headed down to the lounge on her floor. Doctor Mechanical hadn't changed much about the guild's overall layout style; everyone was largely able to navigate easily, even with the new locations that had been added. Part of that consistency included communal areas on every floor where residents could spend time together. Tori noted that once again, she and the other rookies were largely on their own, though that probably

wouldn't last forever. She'd easily counted that there were far more rooms on this floor than were currently being used.

Upon entering, Tori's plans for a simple snack were dashed, as she came upon Warren, Lance, and Beverly, all sans costumes and identities, rooting through the shared fridge. "Whoever stocks this really goes all out. Beers, ciders, sodas—what'll it be?" Lance's meaty arm was shoved halfway into the chilly white box, like it was trying to swallow him whole, only to choke on his wide shoulders.

"I suppose tonight has earned an indulgence. I'll try one of those ciders, please." Warren accepted the can he was given, turning it over a few times in his hand.

Beverly reached in over Lance, grabbing a lager as well as a stout. "More of a wine person, but I've knocked back a few in my day. Tori, I got you." With casual ease, Beverly tossed the stout, which Tori caught easily. After the evening's events, everything felt heightened, right down to her reflexes, though eventually, they'd all crash hard. At least tomorrow was Sunday—no work and hopefully no neighbors.

At the thought of the New Science Sentries, Tori inwardly winced. They definitely hadn't been part of tonight's plan, and a piece of her felt awkward about the idea of seeing them again. That was silly, though, she reminded herself. The capes hadn't dealt with Tori or Beverly tonight. They'd only fought Hephaestus and Bahamut, beings entirely unrelated to the women they shared a building with.

Cracking open her beer, Tori swigged down a sip, saying a silent toast to Ivan and his insistence that she maintain a secret identity. This evening had made her grateful all over again for the distance between Hephaestus and Tori.



Shifting the ice pack elicited a fresh wave of pain, followed by merciful relief. The Alliance of Heroic Champions had many high-tech treatment options for capes who were injured in the field, from basic medical supplies all the way up to a few metas who could actually repair flesh within moments. As with most services, however, priority was determined by

need. On a Saturday night, there were superheroes who required the advanced treatments for injuries far worse than a broken nose.

Donald made no complaints as he waited, sitting on a plastic-lined chair with a rag and an ice pack to handle his injury. Even being here felt ridiculous; except, waiting for the nose to heal naturally would leave a big bright target on his face for everyone they fought. Keeping the injury and being less effective was a folly of pride, something Donald couldn't allow to be more important than the job.

Given that this was the waiting area for low-priority treatments, Donald was more or less alone, with only the occasional attendant stepping in to check on him. When the door opened, that's who he assumed it was, until he caught sight of a familiar blue costume. Rather than go for a rag, Tachyonic had elected to stuff tissues into both his nostrils, a bit of red seeping into view on the white material.

The two met eyes in a shared moment of uncertainty. Despite spending a week together, they were on rough terms; no one outside of Cyber Geek and Agent Quantum had really connected on either team. Tachyonic ultimately made the move, as he was the one still walking. He strode confidently over and took a seat near Donald, without being directly next to him.

"So... that sucked." It was a surprise; those were not the words he'd expected to come out of Tachyonic's mouth, especially not accompanied by a touch of smirk. "You've fought those two before?"

"Sort of. I chased the dragon, Bahamut, while Medley squared off with Hephaestus. They got away that time, too."

"Don't sweat it too much. You're not the one who'll be blamed for this one." Tachyonic's left hand absentmindedly rubbed the empty right spot on his forearm, where a silver bracer would normally be attached. "Between losing the targets and getting exposed, I'm taking the heat for this, which I deserve."

Donald was unexpectedly torn. He wanted to ask what Tachyonic meant by "getting exposed," but wasn't quite sure it had been intended as a conversation option, or if he and Tachyonic were close enough to pose such a question. In the end, his eyes did the asking for him, as Tachyonic realized he was rubbing his arm and caught Donald's stare.

"I'm fast on my own. Could make a go at it as a cape and probably do okay. But to be on the New Science Sentries, okay isn't enough." Tachyonic

tapped the empty space on his arm. “Setlium is stored in devices all along the suit, flooding my cells with extra energy. I’m able to absorb it, thus augmenting my speed. But the bracer is necessary for control, which Hephaestus figured out and broke, resulting in my suit and energy dispersal going haywire.”

“Hope you’ve got spares,” Donald replied. It was a tad flippant, but apparently struck the right cord as Tachyonic chuckled.

He nodded, though the look in his eyes didn’t seem so optimistic. “Professor Quantum builds for contingencies, so I’ve got plenty stowed in various places. The bigger issue is that my secret is exposed. A criminal just figured out my biggest weakness, which means, in no time, everyone will know. Won’t matter in every fight, but for the right enemy, that’s a big opportunity.”

Given the general malaise that had settled on Tachyonic after the brief chuckle, Donald decided it was time to steer the conversation elsewhere. “Sorry if this is rude, Tachyonic, just have to wonder, given our circumstances, is that why you’re here for treatment? I thought super-speed caused fast healing.”

“Fast, sure; good, no,” Tachyonic explained. “The bones already set wrong, so I need to go have it aligned properly. What really smarts is getting whacked there a week after Lodestar did it and told me to keep my guard up.”

“I get it. Kind of surprised Professor Quantum hasn’t made you some sort of shielding or healing devices, though.”

Tachyonic shook his head. “Are you kidding me? No way he’d do something like that.” Pulling himself up straight, Tachyonic affected an annoyed, weary expression paired with a stiff voice. “Pain is a teacher. Cut his lessons short at your own peril.”

It took a moment, but Donald realized he’d been doing a Professor Quantum impression, and not a bad one, at that. “I take it life’s not all that easy being on a legacy team.”

“Being Tachyonic is something I spent my whole life working toward, and there are still days I’ve nearly quit.” He paused, looking over the semi-costume he was still wearing, a more casual version that hung loose at the collar and sleeves. “Also, call me Kyle. We’re on the same side, and as of tonight, we’ve now fought together. Feels like we’re probably to the point of first names, don’t you think?”

“I appreciate that, Kyle. I’m Donald when out of costume, not that it’s a secret.”

“That seems like the life—not having to hide anything. We’re taking a run at the secret identities and barely getting by. Makes you wonder how so many of the crooks pull it off.”

Even if Kyle didn’t say it, Donald knew where both of their minds were turning. “Wondering who’s under that black armored helmet, huh?”

Tenderly, Kyle ran a finger along the bridge of his nose, wincing as he did. “Let’s just say that next time, I’ll be highly motivated to take Hephaestus down and rip off that mask.”

Raising a fist, Donald offered a bump, which Kyle accepted. “When that day comes, give me a call, and we’ll be there to help. My team is now down by two against that pair. I’d love a chance to even the score.”

“Sounds like Hephaestus better watch his ass,” Kyle said. “He’s got some serious superheroes hunting for him as of now.”



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## Chapter 63

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“Absolutely inexcusable. Not only did you fail to arrive on the scene of a large-scale meta-battle, the very sort of incident where you could have turned your reputation around, you missed that opportunity because you were *losing* to a pair of villains. Rookie villains. That is despite having superior numbers and power, mind you. On top of all that, Tachyonic allowed his setlium dispersal control to be broken, compromising him both tonight and for the rest of his career. Do you have any sort of defense to offer up?”

Agent Quantum stood resolute as the tirade washed over him. There were objections he could offer, pointing out that at worst, the night had been a draw. He already knew the reply: if the crooks escaped, then it was a loss by Science Sentry standards. Had he drawn attention to the fact that his team was being careful with escalation, he’d only have to explain why they’d chosen such a tactic in the first place, and there were no happy endings to be found down that path. Instead, he waited until the silence finally loomed, then spoke with his head held low.

“I do not. We made tactical mistakes that led to the escape of our targets. Had we realized they were guild-affiliated in the moment, we’d have taken them more seriously, but we didn’t, and that was our error. *My* error, as team lead, and I’ll accept the consequences.”

The stare from Professor Quantum was harsh, but short. He didn’t have the energy to spare on lingering emotions. With Agent Quantum showing proper remorse and respect, the best option was to move forward.

“I’m glad to hear you at least understand your failings. After getting the full report, I’m starting to see where the team’s issues lie. Come Monday, Tachyonic will be sent back to Vomisa for additional training. Some of our backups have been progressing nicely. I’ll make a new selection that properly compliments the dynamic. Go inform Tachyonic to prepare his things.”

Professor Quantum took a seat at his desk, expecting Agent Quantum to simply leave the office now that the discussion was over. Instead, he looked up to find the team leader still standing there. Unlike before, there was something resolute in his eyes.

“I refuse.”

“Excuse me?”

The young man was nervous, yet did a respectable job of keeping it tamped down, just as he’d been taught. “Tachyonic is my closest friend. He shoulders a sizable amount of responsibility on the team. Removing him over one mistake would only leave us more vulnerable than we already are. It’s not a decision I can support.”

“Agent Quantum, perhaps you’ve become addled by the accolades, but you don’t actually control your team’s makeup. That is my prerogative, and I say Tachyonic is done.”

“Then you can send me back, too.” No give, not even a flicker. Had he come in prepared for this?

Rising slowly, Professor Quantum gave the boy a few iotas of actual attention. Unbending, loyal, determined, Agent Quantum had all the traits Professor Quantum had seen the crowds flock to over the years. Yet instead of loving him, they merely accepted him—and worse, those same qualities were now causing complications. Had this rebellion come a year prior, the entire team may have been tossed out, but things were different now. The team was public, working with Professor Quantum’s seal of approval. Taking one member out due to “injury” was manageable. Losing a team lead was another matter.

“Explain yourself.”

A quick nod, then Agent Quantum replied. “Figurehead or not behind the scenes, I’m the leader of this team in the field. I’m not going to cover for someone if they go on a killing spree; however, I won’t leave my people hung out to dry for doing their best. If Tachyonic’s failure represents anything, it’s a lack of planning and leadership. Whatever his penalty, I’ll

pay it as well. I'm not going to live up to the Science Sentries' legend without my team's support, and they have to know I've got their backs, no matter what."

There had been stronger options for Agent Quantum. Not many, this one was well among the best; however, he wasn't the absolute most powerful in combat. Nor was he the most tactically sound. Some of the weaker candidates had developed mentally to compensate for their failings. It was that attitude that had won him the role, ultimately. Raising the name of the Science Sentries wasn't purely about being the most efficient superhero—hell, they'd actually had to stop Lodestar from doing that when humanity started to grow dependent. No, this was about PR as much as it was the actual saving, and on that front, Agent Quantum had something none of the other candidates could match.

Sincerity. Genuine concern for the people he was helping and love for the job, the sorts of things the public seemed to sniff out. Bad openings or not, with enough time in front of a camera, Agent Quantum was going to win hearts just by being himself. Tachyonic's presence wasn't likely to substantially impede the team, whereas losing Agent Quantum might leave the whole project dead in the water.

Perhaps Tachyonic would make a better collar than sacrifice.

"You want to take responsibility for him, that means whatever comes next is on you. Show me that the team *does* still work in its current composition. Win the people, stop the crimes, and do *not* permit another criminal to escape. I don't care if you want to play tiddlywinks with muggers and vandals: when you face real opponents, do what you were trained for. Take them *down*."

Not quite so sure this time, there was worry on his face, even as Agent Quantum agreed. "Yes, sir. We'll work hard to show you this wasn't a mistake."

"Let's hope so. Because I do not make the same error twice." Professor Quantum settled down to his desk once more. "You're dismissed, Version Nineteen. I don't care if you tell the others about this conversation or not, just make sure they understand you're out of slack. From this point on, failure will not be tolerated."

"Understood." Agent Quantum turned and left the room, shutting the door softly behind him. All that, and not even a slam. For as much distance as lay between Professor and Agent Quantum, they also had more

similarities than the latter realized. That was for the best, though. Such notions only led to attachment, and this was not the right career for that kind of sentiment.

The graves for most of the original Science Sentries, and the multitude of capes who'd fallen since, were all the supporting evidence that hypothesis demanded.



Ivan lowered the phone from his ear, innocuous code phrase already fading. The words had been some fake solicitor offering him a hell of a bargain on used copy machines, whereas the message was quite concise: the traitor was dead. Endless Blitz, once a member of their guild, had been slain tonight.

It wasn't easy, hunting and killing their own, yet it was infinitely easier than managing the guild's defectors if they thought rebellion came without punishment. Another night, it might have been Pseudonym out there, carving carnage out of the betrayer's flesh. Having the kids this weekend had spared him from even the request, though in truth, Ivan would have preferred a hundred bloody battles to the thick tension choking the air in his townhome.

Ever since that morning with Rick, things had been awkward. Better, but still awkward. Whether this was a prelude of things to come or a bump in the road, Ivan had no idea. That would be Rick's call to make, in the end. The most Ivan could offer was the truth when asked, and reassurance that no amount of the past changed where things stood in the present.

He was tempted to touch base with Tori, but that could wait until Monday. Since he'd gotten updates about her team by request, he already knew they were back at the guild safely. That one required a lot less confirmation than making sure they'd killed the right Endless Blitz; the message of Tori's return had come quite a while ago. No need for her to know he was keeping tabs, even if she probably suspected it.

"Dad?" He turned to find Beth standing in the doorway of the stairs, looking confused. Ivan truly had been lost in thought to not even notice her footsteps, soft as they were. "Why are you still up?"

"It is Saturday, isn't it? This is when all the dads stay up for our secret meetings, planning outfits for the coming week to maximize

embarrassment, swapping jokes, comparing notes... general dad stuff.”

Wiping the sleep from her eyes, Beth barely stifled a yawn as she went to the fridge, pulling out a bottle of water. Originally, she’d had cups by the bed, but once they realized what an active sleeper she was, Ivan and Janet had switched her to bottles. It minimized the amount of electrical shorts her alarm clocks would have to endure.

“Is it because you and Rick are fighting?” She walked up to him, smashing roughly against his legs with a hug in half-slumbering state. No fear, no hesitation, just embrace. Ivan savored it, more aware tonight than ever of just how limited these exchanges might be.

“We’re not fighting,” Ivan corrected. “Rick is just coming to terms with new things, sorting out how he feels about them.”

Guiding Beth with him, Ivan walked over to the couch, where she quickly snuggled up against his side, pausing only long enough to take a mighty sip from her water. “You’re up this late because you and Rick *aren’t* fighting?”

Overall, Ivan was deeply grateful that the children took more after Janet than him. That said, there were days when he could have done with them having a tad less of her intelligence and keen observation skills.

“Part of growing up is learning new information about things you thought you already understood,” Ivan explained. “It isn’t always pleasant, and I wish Rick wasn’t having to go through that right now.”

Absentmindedly, he stroked the top of Beth’s skull, just like when she was smaller. A few more years, and this too would be a memory. Time truly was a relentless bastard.

“He’ll be okay. Rick’s grumpy, but also smart and fearless.”

“Fearless?” Ivan loved his son dearly, but that was not the first word that jumped to mind when he thought of him.

Another yawn, this one stretching on for several seconds. “When the school came down, and that metal-person showed up, Rick tried to protect me, throwing books and stuff. He stood between us, even though I was covered in blades.”

It was strange to consider Hephaestus from an outsider’s perspective. While Ivan knew she’d been there to help, to strangers, it must have seemed like she was mounting an attack on the school. The dark armor, the burning jets, and yet Rick had still refused to yield his ground.

While he'd never admit it, for a moment, Ivan wondered if perhaps these fascinating children took more after him than he realized. The important part was that Beth was right. Rick was a good man. Whether that meant Ivan would be forgiven, or even have a relationship going forward with his son, he truly had no idea. But as a father, Ivan had helped to raise the kind of person who stood between someone they loved and a potential killer.

If they never spoke again, Ivan would continue being proud of who his son had become. He'd helped Rick grow into a good, dependable, loyal person. What father had the right to ask, or hope, for more than that?

Soft snores from Beth betrayed that she'd lost the inevitable battle. Gently, like he was holding the most precious gem in the world, Ivan lifted her from the couch, bottle still clutched tightly in her hand. Nearly a teenager, and still small for her age. It wouldn't be long before she was having the same revelations as Rick. How would it feel, to see that same fear reflected in his daughter's eyes?

Ivan put the thought from his head. No need to delve into theoretical tortures when he was already living through a real version. Depositing a brief kiss on her forehead, Ivan walked Beth back upstairs to tuck her into bed. Once she was down, he paused outside of Rick's room, pushing the door carefully open.

Asleep, as he well should be this late at night, Rick looked downright peaceful, an expression Ivan felt he hadn't seen on his son's face in years. Such was the curse of teenagers. In that serene face, Ivan could trace sixteen years' worth of experiences and memories. He could still remember when it was pinched and squealing, being handed off to him by a nervous Janet under the watchful eyes of the Rookstone guards.

That had been right before they went to face Orion, a special visit arranged by Lodestar. The cynic in him said it was because she'd wanted him motivated, fighting with everything on the line. That was why he and most of his ilk would have done it, though. To Lodestar, it was a chance to let him meet his son for the first and likely last time. A picture had gotten him to join. Holding Rick that day... Ivan had learned just what he was truly capable of.

Shutting the door softly, he slipped down the hall. Too many memories were stirred up, flashes of his childhood showing up as well. It was time to call it a night, now that he knew everyone was back safely. There would be

fallout from this; the big scenes always drummed up concern, and he'd need to be on game for the week ahead.

Especially considering next weekend he'd be out in the woods, camping with Lodestar.

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## Chapter 64

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“So, the purpose of the nozzle’s extension—”

“It doesn’t matter what the purpose is. I’m telling you, that thing is way too bulky to be any kind of compact mirror.” Beverly held the aerosolization prototype in her hands, gesturing wilding, making Tori wince slightly whenever it neared the edge of the table. She hadn’t exactly worked on durability just yet. “You either have to shrink it, or find a different product to serve as camouflage.”

A small shriek from the kitchen interrupted them as Chloe was splashed by grease from the pan. After the Saturday they’d been through, it had been nice to spend Sunday relaxing around the apartment. Between the sleeping in and the last few hours tooling around in her lab, Tori was feeling especially refreshed, though the current conversation was draining her fast. She’d been optimistic about integrating the unit into a compact, a notion Beverly seemed intent on disabusing her of.

“Not a hand-mirror then, okay. Wallet?”

“Wallet’s not bad, in theory,” Beverly agreed. “If you were getting mugged, they’d ask you to take it out anyway, so it’s easy to get your hands on. But this thing is a brick. I don’t see people lugging it around all the time the way you have to with a wallet.”

“Plus, it wouldn’t have helped much with your kidnapping.” Chloe slid a charred husk of a flauta from the pan into the trash, adding a fresh one to a now lower-temperature oil. She’d been experimenting with recipes online this morning. So far, this was shaping up about as disastrously as her prior efforts.



Beverly frowned, looking over the item again. “She’s right. That’s sort of the problem with all major self-defense items. You need to be able to get your hands on them in time, meaning you have to already be aware of danger in advance, or get an opportunity to rummage through your purse. Neither is consistently achievable.”

While Tori preferred the storage capacity of a backpack to a purse, she did own a few of the items for more formal occasions. She hadn’t had one on the day in question, so she’d never pictured digging through such an item, but as she replayed the battle in her mind, it was clear there had been no such opening to do so. Beverly was right. The way these devices were most useful was if it was in the victim’s hand already. And to Tori’s thinking, they’d just hit on a very simple way to achieve that.

“Then what if we built these into the purses themselves?” Tori mimed through the air with her hands, drawing the general shape of a handbag. “I can run the wiring up through the handles, create a pair of switches that have to be pressed in unison to prevent misfires, and have the aerosolized deterrent shoot out whichever side we designate for the front. Always in hand, easy to aim, completely non-suspicious—it would even minimize potential chemical blowback.”

Beverly turned the device around once more, no longer looking quite so skeptical. “That could work. Plenty of purses have more heft than this, and you’d be able to fit it into almost anything bigger than a clutch. We’d have to find a way to tell at a glance which way to aim it, ideally without giving away what you’re really holding.” Her gaze drifted off, lost in a flurry of new ideas. It was an expression Tori was intimately familiar with, though she rarely got to see it on others’ faces. “Yeah, I might be able to put something together. It’ll be rough if you want it fast, though.”

“That’s not exactly my most polished work, either.” Tori nodded to her device, proud as she was of it. “Right now, the goal is to show potential. Refinement comes after we prove it works.”

“I’m going to remind you of that when I bust out my first version and you start coming in with notes about thread, design, and—”

The sudden knock made both of them jump, and the flurry of fresh grease pops from the pan meant Chloe had knocked around her current attempt as well. All three looked at each other, the collective mind of the apartment trying to figure out if they had any plans for the day. When no one offered up an explanation, Tori rose from her chair.

“If it’s a salesman, I’m throwing that grease on him,” Tori muttered as she stalked across the room. Before opening the door, she checked to be certain Beverly had tucked the device out of view, then yanked it open.

For a moment, she almost flinched at the sight of Agent Quantum, memories from the prior night’s battle rearing up in her mind. Except it wasn’t Agent Quantum at the door, it was Austin. No costume adorned his body to mark that he was on the job. Even if it had been, he didn’t know he’d recently squared off with two-thirds of the apartment’s occupants.

That much was proven seconds later by his friendly greeting. “Evening, neighbors. How’s the weekend been treating you?”

“Drugs, sex, devil worship—you know. The usual. How’s cape-life?” Without knowing why he was here, all Tori could do was keep things light and hope he’d spill it soon. This was not a situation where she wanted to start guessing.

“Been better. We had a rough one last night—part of why I’m here, actually.” Austin pointed upward, either to Heaven or the roof, or theoretically both, depending on one’s particular love of rooftops. “It was such a shit night, we decided to blow off a little steam. We’re throwing a small party on top of the building tonight. Very small. More of a get-together, really, but there will be food, drinks, and music, so I’ve been assured it counts as a party.”

Tori looked back into the apartment, finding the response warm to neutral. Chloe was still more interested in her cooking practice, and Beverly gave a soft “Why not?” shrug. Having just come to blows with most of the team, Tori wasn’t especially feeling the desire to be social; however, that only made the paranoid part of her brain insist it was all the more necessary to do. Anything that might tip them off to the connection had to be avoided at all costs. Although, even she could admit that might be taking the fear a bit far.

“It sounds like a great time, but Sunday night is kind of a tough one, schedule wise.”

Austin nodded, yet looked undeterred. “I promise, we won’t keep you up too late. And I haven’t even told you the best part. Guess who the other guests are?”

“I mean, it has to be more capes, right? Those are kind of the only people you know in town.”

“Well, yes, though it’s the who in particular that’s notable.” Austin leaned in slightly, as if this was the part that had to be hidden from the walls’ prying ears. “Your friend Donald and his team are going to join us. A week together, and we were barely on speaking terms, but there’s nothing like shared combat to put differences in perspective. I do understand if you three can’t come, just wanted to extend the offer. We probably wouldn’t be on these better terms without your help.”

That complicated matters. Ducking the New Science Sentries was one thing. Avoiding a friend she hadn’t gotten to hang out with in a while was another, far more suspicious matter. There were ways out, excuses she could use to get free, but they would all leave a lingering patina of doubt in people’s minds or risk hurting a friend’s feelings.

“Long as you aren’t offended when I have to turn in for work in the morning, I bet we can swing by. What time does it start?”

“We told the others to be here in about an hour, although Ike and Kyle have already been hauling coolers and decorations up to the roof,” Austin informed her.

From deeper in the apartment, Beverly’s voice piped up. “Decorations? I thought it was just a get-together.”

A ripple of panic seemed to wash over Austin, brief but unmistakable. He recovered in moments, raising his own voice without treading near an actual yell. “It’s our first one in Ridge City. First one anywhere outside of home, actually. We wanted to have some fun with it.”

“Count me in. My curiosity is officially piqued,” Beverly called.

“Me too. I’ll need some dinner. Looks like this recipe is going to take more practice.” Chloe tossed the smoking remains of another flauta into the trash, tying off the bag to prevent the smell from escaping.

Austin’s enthusiasm ratcheted up by several degrees, and Tori didn’t think it had much to do with Chloe joining in. He offered up a big grin and two thumbs, both locked in the “up” position. “Phenomenal. I’ll let the others know, and we’ll see you three soon.”

Tori shut the door once he started walking away, mouthing the word “fuck” as loudly as she dared. After the fight, all she wanted was to spend some time being a normal person—well, normal secret-lab-having inventor, anyway. Now, she was going to spend the evening around the people she and Beverly had traded blows with less than twenty-four hours prior.

It was a good thing Austin had said there would be booze. Tori was definitely going to need a few drinks to make it through this one.



In the streets of Ottawa, children dove into the piles of candy like rich cartoon ducks swimming through a vault of gold. Laying broken in half were the two sides of the giant, tree-shaped piñata, split down the middle by a mighty blow from Rumblejack. The hometown hero was out with the masses, helping direct crowds and traffic amidst the sudden storm of candy coating the streets.

Standing atop a building, watching it all, was *not* a man with kaleidoscope eyes. This one had quite normal brown irises, though his ensemble was certainly more eclectic. Aviator hat and goggles, billowing purple scarf, a pirate-like ruffled shirt, and polka dot pants formed the foundation of his outfit, on top of which were piled a shifting array of accessories. On this occasion, he sported an earring with a three-foot-long peacock feather dangling from his left ear.

There was no warning before the landing; she came in fast. Her actual approach was slower, however, as she cut a casual pace to the edge where he was watching. Once she arrived, he gave a very small nod of greeting. “Lodestar.”

“Captain Bullshit,” she replied. Taking a long look over the edge, Lodestar surveyed the scene. “Still teaching people to expect the unexpected, I see.”

“It is the burden of many lifetimes. I simply do my part.” He never really turned to her, his attention locked on the exhibition he’d painstakingly created below.

“By blocking traffic for miles and causing general disarray.” Lodestar pointed to the long line of lights stretching out into the distance, all caused by the unexpected appearance of a skyscraper-sized pinata and its subsequent destruction.

Captain Bullshit adjusted his goggles slightly; otherwise, he seemed unaffected by the accusation. “It’s a break in the routine, a crack in the mundane, a chance for people’s lives to take unpredicted turns. Have you come to try and take me back for offering them this opportunity?”

“I obviously should. This is disturbing the peace at a very bare minimum. The problem is we both know that capturing you is almost impossible, and holding you against your will actually *is* impossible. Right now, the AHC is stretched thin. Trying to take down a reality-warper of your level would be dangerous, to both us and the surrounding area.”

“Shall I take it that you concede?” Captain Bullshit shifted slightly, only to find Lodestar directly next to him. He’d never heard a peep or felt so much as a whiff in the wind. Powerful though he was, she couldn’t be brushed aside.

She nodded down to the street, where the kids were still stuffing their faces with sweets. “Not in the slightest. This sort of stuff, I can live with. It’s far from ideal, but nobody got hurt. Nowhere near worth the death toll from trying to take you down. Don’t change that equation. Don’t become a danger I have to stop. You know where you overstepped last time. Count your years in Rookstone as time served and please don’t make the same mistakes again.”

At first, she thought he would ignore her, but eventually, Captain Bullshit bobbed his head ever so slightly. “Bound as I am by the direction of the art, I can acknowledge that hurting people in the displays lessens the audience who receives the message as a whole.”

While it wasn’t a firm commitment to not injure civilians, it was something. Given that Lodestar was dealing with someone whose power to manipulate reality functioned on a planet-wide scale, this was the best outcome she could hope for. Captain Bullshit wouldn’t be stopped easily; she’d only managed to get him into Rookstone through a tactic that wouldn’t work twice. Until they found a way to seal his abilities, it was better to have an occasional nuisance pester the world than have an entire nation be changed into a smoking crater, or worse.

“I appreciate it,” she said. Lodestar almost took back to the sky, but decided instead to knock out one last question, considering the opportunity. “Since we’re both here, I’ve been wondering about something. We aren’t finding any of the criminals who escaped from Rookstone. It’s like they vanished. No amount of tech or magic can get us a location. Would you happen to know anything about that?”

For the first time, Lodestar’s words produced a real reaction, a wide grin that brightened Captain Bullshit’s face considerably. “A gift, to them, and to the capes.”

“How is hiding them a gift for us?”

The smile only grew bigger. “What glory is there in scooping them up when they are freshly released and weakened? This gives them the chance to recover, grow stronger, offer up a proper challenge to the Alliance of Heroic Champions. You’d have been little more than animal control wrangling escaped beasts. Now, you’ll have the chance to show the world *your* art once more. I imagine we will be in for glorious displays, once they begin to act in earnest.”

That more or less confirmed her suspicions, as well as hinting that Captain Bullshit’s protection might fade once the escapees got active. Annoyed as she was by the whole ordeal, Lodestar still forced a polite tone into her voice as she said her farewell. “Really wish you wouldn’t have, but I appreciate the heads up. Remember what we talked about, for everyone’s sake. I much prefer these cordial visits.”

She flew off into the sky, her light slowly fading, leaving Captain Bullshit continuing to assess his handiwork. He watched her go, saddened by the spectacle. So much power, yet only the barest amount was ever allowed to shine through. One day, he would set a proper stage for her, give the art a genuine outlet. That would be an ambitious project for another time, however.

For now, he had years of ideas ready to be unleashed, most of which wouldn’t even violate Lodestar’s rule. As for the ones that did, he’d worry about those when he got to them. It wasn’t like he was in a hurry. Captain Bullshit was free, and the world was his canvas. After years in prison, he planned to savor the smaller projects before stirring up any real trouble.

He couldn’t risk being rusty once the true art began.

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## Chapter 65

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Given the choice between navigating the social minefield of a party with two sets of capes she'd been fighting the night prior, or going through guild initiation training again, Tori easily would have suited up for another day of chasing robots with metal orbs inside. Sadly, no one was offering her such an option, which meant she had to step out onto the rooftop with Chloe and Beverly, officially joining the New Science Sentries' soiree.

The "decorations" that had been promised were sets of lights running between every remotely elevated point to and fro, creating a twinkling, overhead spiderweb. There were smaller touches, as well—a plant here, a tiki statue there—but it was still a level of decor meant to be broken down when the night was through. Featured prominently in the center was a large barbecue pit from which smoke was already rising, tinged with the mouthwatering scent of something roasting. Next to it were two coolers, one of which was open as the thick-fingered form of Ren pulled a pair of beers from the ice.

Like everyone else on the rooftop, he looked human, though in his case, Tori suspected trickery was afoot; she'd realized since their first meeting that he was really Medley. Tonight, his appearance was slightly more formal, with a collared shirt squeezing tightly around his robust form. Illusion, hologram, or full-on magic, all that bulk of Medley's still had to be accounted for.

While she'd never seen them out of mask, the duo talking to Donald and Austin had to be Hat Trick and Cold Shoulder, by process of elimination. Also, it wasn't especially hard to guess when seeing them alongside the rest

of their team. Both were dressed slightly upscale, like they were going to a corporate cocktail hour. It made Tori glad she'd allowed Beverly to bully her into a blouse instead of an old t-shirt, along with a smattering of makeup. The goal was to minimize standing out, and fitting into the scene helped to make that easier.

"Pardon us, got some more supplies for the shindig." Kyle's voice caused Tori to jump aside, clearing the rooftop entrance for him, Ellie, and Ike, all arriving with armfuls of accoutrement. Chips, plates, cups, ice, all the party essentials outside of actual refreshments.

Beverly reached out to help, but her hand closed on empty air as Ike vanished, reappearing next to a table covered by a bright blue tablecloth. "Speak for yourself. Some of us just needed line of sight. So lazy, this one. No wonder we have to keep on him."

Ellie was already stalking toward him, the look on her face all the warning Ike needed to dart out of her path.

Muttering under his breath, Kyle blurred momentarily, depositing his burden onto the table and arranging it neatly before reappearing at Tori's side only a few seconds later. This wasn't nearly as fast as Tachyonic moved, however, a detail that Tori couldn't help but note. How much was the difference with and without the suit, she wondered. And did he have a backup bracer? For the first time, it occurred to Tori she might have taken him out of the field entirely until his tech was back up and running. Even more oddly, that didn't sit quite right in her stomach. There wasn't time to process the issue, as Kyle greeted her with the standard stiff half-hug of neither full friends nor casual acquaintances.

"Glad you three could make it. After last night, we all needed to blow off some steam. Wouldn't be the same without our neighbors."

"It's a nice gesture, especially for someone you're just assigned to bodyguard." Tori didn't really expect this to work, but it was important to at least try to keep some distance between her and the New Science Sentries.

To her surprise, Kyle managed an actual laugh. Had losing a fight made him less uptight? Now that was an unexpected side effect. "I guess you're not wrong, but honestly, at this point, you're also the only friends we've really made in this town. But hey, maybe things are turning around on that front." His attention was on Donald and the others, who were looking over as well thanks to the flurry of activity.



Finally noticing her arrival, Donald broke off from his conversation, walking over to embrace Tori warmly. She returned the gesture. It was nice to see him again outside of capes, masks, and kidnapping. When they broke apart, Tori thought she saw Kyle staring, though, when she looked closer, he appeared to be looking past them, at the barbecue.

“Well, well, well, the great superhero finally has time to see his friends from the cubicle days. Let me guess, you want to know if Barb is still pushing for Popcorn Fridays, or if Mustache Stan ever took the hint about microwaving fish.”

“All of it, all of it and more. Don’t you dare skip over the detailed minutes from the last monthly status meeting.”

Tori chuckled, even as the others stared in confusion. Running office jokes didn’t tend to actually be funny; they were more comforting, a constant one could depend upon. In that brief exchange, Tori saw a flash of the old Donald, before the weight of superpowers and the duty they entailed had been yoked around his shoulders. Pleasant though the glimpse was, Tori brought them back to the present. “You know, everyone is really proud of you. When your team does something big, it gets brought up in meetings; Barb even has a ‘Cyber Geek’s Greatest Hits’ wall where she posts news clippings.”

The words hit heavier than she’d expected. Donald almost seemed to have the breath drop out of him. “That’s... unexpected. Your uncle mentioned there was some support the last time we spoke. I never imagined it would be that much. When I was around after the change, most of them seemed so uncomfortable, not sure of how to act around me.”

“People don’t always respond to change well, or quickly,” Beverly interjected. “Obviously doesn’t hurt that now they’re seeing you out there all the time, helping innocents and saving the day.” She patted him once on the shoulder, then wandered over to the coolers with Chloe close behind.

Since Donald still seemed momentarily taken aback, Kyle jumped on the opportunity to join the conversation. “It sounds like you work with your uncle? That’s got to be an interesting experience.”

Every single warning light in Tori’s brain flashed like a nuclear launch had just been announced. Of all the fucking things to mention, Donald had to bring up Ivan. Worse, he mentioned their fake connection, meaning Tori was about to be intrinsically linked to him. Donald was one thing—he was fully tricked by Ivan’s mundane persona. If the New Science Sentries got

too close, they might catch something, and that could lead to all manner of trouble.

Unfortunately, try as she might, her brain refused to offer up any solution for how to dodge the question while in Donald's presence. He minimized her ability to obfuscate or lie, so her only choice was to tell the truth, and *really* lean on how boring and unworthy of discussion her supposed uncle was.

"Oh yeah, it's the best. Total adherence to schedule, constantly double-checking my work, endless feedback, whether I want it or not. Ivan's a good uncle and a solid manager, but he's so uptight and by-the-book."

The small nods from Donald backed up her claim nicely. "While Mr. Gerhardt is one of the better bosses I've had, he does tend to be a bit stiff."

Tori spotted the approach as it was coming, the two forms she'd yet to meet out of costume wandering over, arriving behind Donald before he registered their presence. The shorter one tapped a finger on her team leader's arm, digging the nail in slightly to make sure he noticed.

"Going to introduce us?"

Donald didn't seem to mind the nail—that might just be her way, and he was accustomed to it. He greeted the arrival with the same timid smile as always, gesturing to both women as he faced Tori. "Of course. Perfect timing, too. Tori, this is Irene and Lucy. We work together, and you can probably guess how, but I'll keep the details light. Irene and Lucy, Tori is a friend of mine from my cubical days."

"Trust me, we know," Irene commented. She extended a hand to Tori, which Tori accepted. The woman didn't seem especially distant to her, in particular; rather, her persona read more as an overall antisocial aura, something Tori could not only respect, but understood and envied. Left to her own devices, she'd be affecting a similar vibe, or skipping the outing entirely.

Lucy didn't offer a hand. Instead, she gripped Tori in a tight hug the moment Irene let go and she turned to face the freckled woman. "It's wonderful to meet you! Donald has told us such nice things. I can't wait to get to know you better."

Was there such thing as social whiplash? If so, Lucy and Irene were the tag-team champs of it. Barely recovered, Tori did her best to return the dual greeting. "Good to meet you both, as well. What's say we all move away

from the doorway and into the party proper? That cooler is calling my name.”

“A woman after my own heart.” Ike materialized at the edge of the group, sipping from his own open bottle. “If I had one, anyway. Donald, Ren sent me over. Ellie wanted to get some games going and your buddy said you were the man to see.”

Looking somehow sheepish, despite the innocuous request, Donald offered Tori an apologetic shrug. “The joys of being the item guy.”

“I had to chill all the drinks. We pitch in where we can.” Irene clapped him on the back. “Come on. We’ll force Ren to hurry up and choose so you can get back to the revelry.”

“Let’s talk more later,” Lucy called to Tori, before following them both over to Ren.

Ike vanished again, reappearing next to Ren and leaving Tori alone with Kyle, who didn’t linger before gesturing to the refreshment area. “I believe you mentioned needing a drink.”

“Excellent listening skills. Those will take you far.” They walked together over to the cooler, her taking a beer while Kyle pulled out a glass container with what appeared to water inside, marked by three X’s in a row, like an old-time moonshine jug.

“Damn it, Ike, that wasn’t what I meant when I said to label these.” Kyle yelled the words, but Ike’s attention was lost in the sparks of blue light as Donald produced various objects for the night’s activities. “I didn’t want anyone to drink this by mistake. Not healthy for those without super-speed metabolism.”

Cracking the lid, Kyle took a sip, his whole body tensing as the liquid passed his lips. “Oof. That is terrible every time. Cheers?” He held up his bottle, to which Tori clinked her own.

It was surreal to see the New Science Sentries like this, less than a day after fighting with them. In the field, they’d been terrifying. Fast, brutal, efficient—only quick thinking and a few surprises had kept her people out of jail. Yet tonight, they looked like little more than a few goofballs in their twenties. Then again, what did she look like to them? And what would their impression of Ivan be? The more Tori pondered it all, the more she wondered how many other people in her past had been living double lives. The deeper into all of this she got, the harder it was not to speculate about how much she’d missed before.

“Part of me has always been jealous of this.” With a sweeping gesture, Kyle motioned to the entire roof and all its merrymakers. “Live a normal life, make friends, have fun, be happy. Regular people don’t worry about whether or not they’ll be blown apart by some unknown meta, or fail to save someone in peril.”

“Actually, *everyone* worries about the first one—it’s just part of life these days,” Tori corrected. “I’ll give you the second point, though.” She examined Kyle’s face, not sure if even he knew how wistful it currently appeared. “You could have that, if you really wanted it. Nobody is forced to be a cape.”

“No, I couldn’t. Even if I had it in me to leave my friends behind, it’s only the parts like this that I envy. Tomorrow morning, all the people with normal jobs will wake up to go to work at things they probably don’t care about, simply powering through their days. I’m going to wake up and make the world better, might even get to save a few people. There’s no trading that life in, once it has its teeth in you. When all is said and done, this is the only job for me, so I have to be good at it.”

The kick Tori could still recall ringing her entire suit seemed to indicate that Kyle was well on his way to achieving that, but she couldn’t exactly say it. Instead, she went with something more suited to her perspective than Hephaestus’s. “I’m no expert on capes, but for what it’s worth, every time I’ve seen you fuck up, you own it. You take responsibility and try to fix it or improve, so there won’t be repeats. It hasn’t escaped my notice that no more saved civilians have ended up in Tachyonic’s arms on camera.”

“Maybe I just haven’t saved anyone else worthy of sweeping off their feet.”

Tori rolled her eyes at what she assumed to be a joke, then kept on going. “My point is, if your goal is to be a great superhero, learning from your mistakes seems like an excellent policy to have. Keep that up, and eventually, you’ll run out of new mistakes to make. Pretty sure that’s what they call being competent.”

From the other end of the roof, a cheer went up as tennis rackets were being passed out while Donald was summoning flashing orbs the size of softballs. Ike appeared directly in front of Tori and Kyle, holding a racket in each hand.

“The game has been chosen. It’s sort of like racquetball, only with magic balls that fly around. From some game called *Electro-Sport Rodeo*,

which I might have to buy the next time we've got a day off. Take your weapons and come gather for the choosing of teams. If you're last, they'll stick you with me."

Lifting the racket he'd been handed, Kyle waved it slightly. "Guess that means it's game on?"

"Eh, why not? It'll help work up an appetite for dinner." More importantly, playing an active game made conversation harder, and they'd done plenty of talking for Tori's tastes.

Besides, some part of her couldn't resist the opportunity for a rematch, even if the game was different this time around.

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## Chapter 66

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Taking a sip from her plastic cup of wine, Beverly surveyed the rooftop scene carefully. Unlike Tori, she hadn't spent the majority of her life eyeball deep in electronics, meaning she had a better grasp of social nuance. Not that the talent was especially called for—most people would have picked up on the dynamics at play, if not spotted them immediately.

Donald and Tori were sitting on chairs, plates loaded with barbecue, catching up on life. While they weren't technically alone—others were seated near them—by keeping the topic to their old lives, they'd effectively locked everyone else out of the conversation. For most of the other revelers, that was no matter at all, but two of the attendees seemed not-quite-comfortable with how familiar the former coworkers were.

One of them, Beverly had seen coming. It wasn't hard to note the way Kyle's fondness for Tori had grown through their interactions. Maybe it was her lack of giving a shit about superheroes, or her brusque nature, but something had been winning him over despite their initial impression. Not that Tori appeared to have registered even the slightest iota of it. It was hard to be too tough on her, given that Donald was getting the same looks thrown his way from Lucy. While there was a chance those glances were out of concern for a team member, it wouldn't be the bet Beverly tossed her money on.

Ike was still occasionally turning his head toward Ellie, who was mostly talking to Austin and Lucy, as Ren and Chloe were in a discussion about a surprise shared interest in some obscure winter sport they'd evidently both grown up watching. Between all the secret identities and hidden feelings,

Beverly was starting to feel like she'd stepped into a meta-human version of high school. Not great, but then, she hadn't been able to turn into a dragon in real high school. That wasn't a terrible trade-off.

"Taking a breather?" Of all the capes on the roof, Irene was the easiest to lose track of. Short, intentionally bland wardrobe, largely quiet, she essentially vanished amidst the larger forms and personalities of the others.

"Enjoying the stars for a moment." Beverly had selected her seat partially for this excuse, as it was the point on the roof furthest from any light source. That also made it furthest from sound and activity and was an excellent spot for unwinding.

Irene also boasted a plastic cup, the fizz from within marked it as either a soda or a cocktail, rather than wine. She took a soft sip, then settled down onto one of the cheap lawn chairs dotting the roofscape. Once she was comfortable, she drank once more, then let out a grunt.

"Spot anything interesting?"

"Stars don't tend to change," Beverly replied.

"These days, you never know. I wasn't talking about the sky, though." Irene pointed over to the party, then to Beverly herself. "You're over here hugging the sidelines, trying to get a read on everyone."

Beverly wasn't entirely sure how to react, largely because she didn't know if the words were meant as a compliment or an insult. Rather than make a guess, she decided to play things neutral. "That's an interesting way to look at it. Here I thought I was just taking a breather."

"Maybe you were, and I got the wrong read. Doesn't happen often, mind you. When you're easy to ignore, people let down their guard; helps with catching details. I'm doing pretty well tonight, though, this snafu not counted. Clocked Donald's crush on Tori, and of course, there's Lucy's on Donald. Seems Ike has some unresolved feelings of his own, and then there's Austin."

Those looks, Beverly hadn't caught as many of. That was the nature of things, it was always easier to observe as an outsider. She'd seen snippets of enough to know that they were there. Short flashes, never overt, slightly too constant to be a coincidence. Austin was a knot of complications, none of which Beverly felt like diving into with someone she'd just met. "I work hard to look good. Doesn't bother me that he took notice."

"Except, he's not the only one who hasn't been as discreet as they think." Irene punctuated the statement with another sip from her cup, eyes

darting between Beverly and Austin, just in case there was any confusion.

“This is a strange way to try to make new friends.” Beverly didn’t have a reasonable defense to offer: explaining that she’d been watching him in case he was watching her didn’t sound real in her head, let alone as actual words. Her only option was to redirect and hope they veered into a more manageable topic.

“Never been something I’m very good at,” Irene agreed. “A little too observant, and much too honest. Thought I might have spotted a kindred soul, but if that’s not the case, then sorry to have bothered you.”

The chair scraped along the rough surface as Irene pushed it back, rising to her feet. Beverly had a snap judgment to make. Before her current living situation, she would have let the cape walk away, happy for the interaction to be over. Time with Tori had given Beverly more insight to the less socially inclined, however. While it would have been easy to read the whole exchange as an uncomfortable moment, she could also recognize that it had been Irene attempting to reach out, in her own odd way.

“Stop,” Beverly commanded, her tone far more certain than it had been moments prior. “Sit and relax. You weren’t necessarily wrong, that doesn’t mean I want to talk about it.”

Pausing only to readjust the chair so it was angled to better face Beverly, Irene retook her seat. “I can understand that. How about something more standard to first meetings: what do you do?”

The smile on Beverly’s face threatened to push Irene back with how fast and strong it came on. Had she been praying for a topic she could speak on at length without going anywhere near romance or capes, Beverly might have thought someone up there was actually listening.

“What do I do? Settle in, because I’m about to explain the economics of running a fashion content website.”

For as good as Irene might have been at reading facial cues, she wasn’t especially adept at concealing her own horrified expression.



Turning the orb around in her long fingers, Lozora examined the handiwork. She’d never gotten to see any of Cobblord’s creations up close and personal before; in Rookstone, he’d been denied any materials for



obvious reasons. On the inside, he'd been a quiet, bookish man who kept to himself. He'd have been eaten within the first week, if not for his usefulness. Cobblord's particular talent made him handy enough to earn protection from some of the more dangerous residents of Rookstone's lowest levels, a debt he'd apparently been paying off since he regained his freedom.

What she held now was a custom job, and not a cheap one, either. Much as she'd have liked to knock it on the side like she was checking a mango, the truth was, she had no idea what she was looking at. It could be a round rock with fancy designs for as much as she could tell. Rather than read the product, Lozora elected to keep her attention on Cobblord's bespectacled face.

"You're sure this will hold Fornax?"

"Certainly not." For as nervous as he always looked, the trepidation never touched his voice. "To my knowledge, that's impossible. It will contain Fornax, for a time, until he breaks free. How long that will take, I can't say. I added a lot of distance, so it would take time to travel, and some obstacles along the way, but there's really no stopping Fornax. Only slowing him down, which is what I was hired to do."

Cockier now that he had a bit of leverage, though Lozora couldn't fault him for drilling down on specifics. Working with these sorts of people meant that, when things went wrong, blame was quick to be spread, so Cobblord wanted to be explicit about what his product was supposed to do. It was a pointless worry. She wouldn't have the option to kill him until the second version was completed, and even then, it was an order she'd probably ignore. Her current employer was scary; that didn't mean he was the person that terrified Lozora the most.

"Fine, so this will slow Fornax down. We deploy it this weekend. I'll bring the results afterward. He'll expect a quick turnaround time on this one."

"They always do. Updates are easier than creation. I still have the model that one was cast from." Cobblord nodded to the orb, then spun in the leather chair, turning back to his workstation. "It was good to see you, Lozora. Now that I know you're my go-between, I'll have appropriate snacks for our next meeting. As I recall, you enjoyed the composition of weight lifters the most."

She stowed the orb, unexpected hospitality dispelling her more murderous thoughts. Perhaps there was a reason he'd survived on the inside beyond just his talent, or maybe he simply had good manners. Regardless, Lozora wasn't going to turn down food on a trip she'd have to make anyway. Especially considering the crap her current employer kept around.

"Keep up the good work, Cobblord. I'd like it if all my visits could go this pleasantly. Saves me from having to lap up the blood."



"Tori! Ren just had an awesome idea. Their team has next Saturday afternoon off—what do you say we all go mini-golfing?" Chloe's enthusiasm was exuberant, even as Ren's face made it clear this was more a casual suggestion than a vetted plan. Nice as the night had gone, Tori was glad she had an actual excuse for the outing, one that would cover her even if they tried to change around the times.

"No can do, I'm gone all next weekend, remember?" Only once those words were out of her mouth did Tori note the curious stares and realize exactly *what* that excuse was.

It was Ike who posed the question; the people she actually knew were polite enough to let it slide. "Weekend long trip? You didn't strike me as the music festival type, but as long I'm out of costume, sounds like a good time."

Embarrassing as the truth would be for a villain to admit, she took a small amount of pleasure in dashing whatever delusions Ike had spun for himself. At least only Beverly and Chloe would see the full humor in the situation, and they were already up to speed. "My uncle is a Starscout cluster leader, and I pitch in to help. The End of Summer Shindig is some big camping event, so I'll be in the woods battling bugs and filth."

"Add in some hallucinogens, and it's still pretty close to a music festival." Ike's reply was largely lost in the clamor of words amidst Tori's explanation. It wasn't the organization that stuck out to them, rather the one who'd founded it.

"You know, now that I think about it, it's kind of weird we don't do work with the Starscouts," Ellie said. "If Lodestar asked, there'd be no shortage of capes who'd volunteer."

Tori shook her head. “Separate entities, by Lodestar’s own design. She didn’t want the kids becoming targets used for drawing in capes, or the organization to be too connected to the AHC, in case someone got the idea to use it as a recruiting pool. Some capes do volunteer, but on their own, not under the AHC banner.” This much hadn’t been leftover memories from childhood, rather a bit of knowledge absorbed from Helen, who enjoyed sprinkling historical tidbits through the meetings. She evidently had a passion for history, at least where the Star Scouts were concerned.

“Guess that means we won’t be able to follow you up there and make wolf noises. Shame, I’ve got a decent howl.” Ike tilted his head back, as if to give a display, but thought better of it when he caught the death-glare in Ellie’s eyes.

Austin, on the other hand, appeared genuinely concerned. He rubbed his chin, his eyes never fully leaving Tori. “Are you sure that’s safe? Out in the woods, away from society? Seems like the kind of place well suited to another attempt on your life.”

Out in the woods, away from witnesses and police, Tori would be far more dangerous than she was masquerading through mundane life. Powers and tech could be used freely in that situation—none of which she could very well tell Austin. “Look, before you get the bright idea to send a tail along, this is a huge event. Clusters from all over the state meet up. I’m not saying we’re immune to meta-attacks, nowhere can boast that, but I’m pretty sure there’s a few security measures in place, given that there’s tons of kids hanging around up there.”

That was without even mentioning Ivan, who was more than enough on his own, and could be motivated to truly horrific levels if anything put Beth in danger.

“Attacking Lodestar’s charity organization seems like an especially dumb move,” Donald added. “There’s no way she doesn’t keep some tabs on it.”

A robust, far-from-demure laugh escaped from Ellie’s lips. “Sorry, I just imagined some idiots showing up, thinking all they had to deal with there were children, and finding Lodestar waiting for them instead.”

A ripple of chuckles and shudders rolled through the revelers as they all pictured the hypothetical scenario for the half-second necessary to see its inevitable conclusion. Even Austin looked more relaxed, perhaps realizing

he'd been overly concerned. "That is a pretty amusing mental image. Doesn't even really matter who the challenger is."

"Well... except Fornax." Like a conversational sniper, Irene killed the light mood with a single phrase. She noticed the sudden deflation as the collective shoulders sagged, but showed no remorse. "What? He held his own with Lodestar back in the day, and now we know he was never really dead. Maybe you managed to avoid seeing any video from the Ridge City Riots, but I watched him smack around Apollo like a cat playing with a mouse. Even the Champions' Congress has enemies on their level."

"Been trying hard not to think about that," Ike admitted. "Though I do have to wonder, where do you hide Fornax for over a decade? Space, right? Had to be space. He'd have torn up any city they let him loose in."

Tori suddenly found herself extremely uncomfortable with the topic of conversation, and worse, she had absolutely no way to signal that without provoking suspicion. None she could think of, at any rate. She shot a brief glance to Beverly, who met the gaze yet said nothing. She'd help where she could, but neither of them was steering this ship.

"Maybe he went civilian," Chloe suggested. "Turned it all around and started living a normal life." For a brief moment, Tori thought she felt her heart actually stop, until she noticed the amused faces on almost all of the capes' faces.

"We would classify that as unlikely." Ren kept his tone as gentle as possible, but there was no getting around the disagreement. "Someone as destructive as Fornax keeping control on his own is probably impossible; if he could have fit in with society, he'd have done that from the start."

No, he wouldn't, because he never had the chance. He spent eighteen years being forced to kill the only people he knew, then was saddled with a destructive force from another plane before ever setting foot in "society." The man they thought of as some wild monster was in fact the most controlled person Tori had ever met. Not that she could tell them that, or any of the other insights into who that villain they knew only by name really was. It was strange; even though the assumptions were helping Tori and Ivan keep their secrets, it still pissed her off that they were being made. These people thought they knew their enemies, but they didn't have the first fucking idea what was really going on.

For a moment, she'd been able to forget what the actual dynamic of the evening was. It had been pleasant, pretending they were just a bunch of

young people hanging out and having fun. But that was an illusion, one she couldn't afford to get lost in. This was eight capes hanging out with the two villains who'd slipped their clutches one night prior. If any of them knew who she really was, all their friendliness would evaporate instantly.

Tori had to remember those lines, keep them firmly in mind. One day, if her secret was ever exposed, these capes would probably become her fiercest enemies, feeling betrayed by her deception. She wouldn't even begrudge them that, the enmity would be well deserved. Still, Tori would be better off if she started distancing herself from them once the bodyguard work was over. In all honesty, she knew she should do the same with Donald, as well.

Alliances were one thing, but the longer she had to keep all these lies in place, the more Tori suspected that capes and villains simply couldn't be friends.

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## Chapter 67

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“At 1:07 a.m., local time, the first alerts were triggered. After I arrived on the scene and began a preliminary investigation, it took less than ten minutes to confirm what we were looking at: extraterrestrials, moving en masse toward our planet. Given the size and number of ships, there can be no question that this is meant to be an invading force. I’ve asked Cresscriss to sit in and offer his expertise, where applicable.”

For once, Lodestar didn’t mind Professor Quantum’s brusque nature. Given what this Monday morning meeting was about, she was glad to quickly cut to the heart of the matter. They’d known more encounters were possible but hadn’t been expecting any after the Grzzniltan forces went fleeing to the stars.

On a large TV screen, several grainy images appeared, showcasing a vast army of ships with a strange, twisting design, like someone had tried to make a spaceship modeled after a particularly gnarly knot.

“Wrexwren,” Cresscriss muttered. Two of his six eyes closed for a long breath as his fingers pressed against the blue skin of his skulltip. “A species whose culture is based predominantly on war and conquest. Since they are part of a loose affiliation of spacefaring peoples, the Wrexwren direct those tendencies toward planets that have yet to reach the stars and attain such protections.”

“Perhaps the Grzzniltans passed them inaccurate information, painting us as an easy target? If they’ve got any enmity toward the Wrexwren, it would allow them to use us as a blunt instrument of vengeance,” Quorum suggested.

Cresscriss made a sound like a sparrow taking a shot of vodka.

“Unlikely. The Grzzniltans prize survival, and large as this force is, that in no way represents the entirety of the Wrexwren armada. Such a deception would bring intense repercussions, but I suppose it is possible if there’s an angle we’ve yet to discover.”

“I don’t care about their motivations. We’ve established them to be hostile. Let’s engage the planetary defense cannons and be done with it. I’ve made great strides in improving them through the years—if we strike before they’re prepared, there is minimal chance any will survive.” No one in the room doubted that if they gave the okay, Professor Quantum would fire on the fleet before the hour was over. That was part of why it took the entire Champions’ Congress to activate them; it had been her and Quorum’s condition on allowing the weapons to be built.

“Before we blow potentially thousands of living beings into dust, how about we entertain the possibility that they’re coming here peacefully? Being from a war-faring species doesn’t change the fact that a sentient creature makes its own choices. Some choose to rebel against the reality they’re presented. Maybe this is a band of Wrexwren outcasts seeking a planet to live in peace upon.”

It wasn’t especially loud, said mostly under his breath, but she noted Quorum’s whisper: “That’s a *lot* of outcasts.”

Thankfully, Cresscriss came to her aid, in spite of what she felt ninety percent sure was a skeptical expression on his face.

“There is another option to preemptive destruction. The Wrexwren are also a people who take great pride in their strength. I have heard tales that they will settle these matters with a contest of warriors—the greatest of the planet against the strongest of their own. Should they be defeated, the invasion would be called off out of respect for any planet that could birth such a combatant. However, I have never engaged with them directly, so I cannot attest to the viability of such a tactic.”

A click from the remote in Professor Quantum’s hand brought up a new image, this one harder to puzzle out. At first, it looked like another angle with fewer ships, until Lodestar noticed all the darkness. Something was there, blotting out the stars that should be visible, yet it registered as nothing more than a hole in the photo, like the object had been torn out.

“There is another concern. They are hauling something with them, an object my scanners and cameras have thus far been unable to detect. Unless

that is standard procedure for the Wrexwren people, we should prepare to be surprised. I doubt they would make this approach without something that gave them the idea of victory.”

Mysterious alien force approaching from the sky? It felt like a fight. In her gut, Lodestar knew where this was heading. Blasting, punching, hurting—she could already feel the cold of space pulling at her skin. But sometimes, on a few wonderful and cursedly rare occasions, she was wrong. Every now and then, things weren’t what they appeared, and it didn’t have to end in combat. She had to fight for those possibilities, especially because so few of the other capes even believed in them.

“Hail the ships,” Lodestar said. “Ask them their intent, and if it’s invasion, see if they’re open to that one-on-one option Cresscriss mentioned.”

“They could lie,” Professor Quantum pointed out.

“Good thing they’ll be talking to the smartest superhero in history, whose brilliance can easily sniff out such deceptions.” Lodestar thought about the first screen again and the sheer number of ships that had been approaching. If things did get bad, that was too many to take out safely. For the Wrexwrens’ sake, she dearly hoped they turned out to be anomalies.

Cresscriss cleared a vocal sack, a noise akin to pudding falling on a tile floor. “I’m not saying attack need be the first recourse; however, you should know that right now is the optimum time to strike. The ships appear to be prioritizing speed, meaning that power to their shields will be minimal. Once they know you’re alerted to their presence, that energy distribution will change. A shot fired preemptively would have the greatest chance of success.”

The words hung heavy in the room, quickly dispelled by a nonchalant wave from Quorum. “Doesn’t matter. ‘Shoot first’ is not the way superheroes work. Besides, more shields or fewer, it changes nothing. If they’re peaceful, we greet them; if not, we send them away.”

“The Wrexwren are a powerful species. I would caution against underestimating them. You three would no doubt triumph against their soldiers; I’m not sure the rest of the AHC will fare as well.”

“Thank you, Cresscriss. Your information has been invaluable, and I’ll need your aid to be sure the Grzzniltan translators we constructed can work on Wrexwren language, as well. It seems we’ll be making contact soon.” Professor Quantum looked unhappy, but when wasn’t that the case? He was



much too smart to have actually expected to shoot the lasers; Lodestar would bet he'd already started work on updating their translator. In spite of how much he could push the limits, Professor Quantum had been doing this job longer than anyone else, and had a keen grasp on the way things usually went.

"Since we know what we're going to do, that leaves us with only one major item to get figured out." Lodestar tapped a lightly glowing nail against the polished wood of the table. "First contact with an entire new section of the universe. What do we want to say?"



"Nice ass!"

Johnny Three Dicks smacked the oversized posterior of Thuggernaut as he arrived, earning an annoyed glare from much higher up. There was no remorse in his eyes as he dodged a half-hearted swipe for his skull. "What? I can't take note that my buddy got some new pants?"

"Not the way most people would acknowledge that." Stasis wandered into the room with a gigantic bag of chips in hand, pilfered from some unknown source. She paused, taking in Thuggernaut's non-costumed form, giving a small nod of approval. "Outfit looks nice. Got something fancy going on?"

"Opera tickets," Thuggernaut explained. "In a time zone where it's nearly evening, for a show that starts worryingly soon. Hopefully this doesn't take too long. I only popped by to see what the announcement was."

He, Johnny, and most of the other gathered villains had all gotten the same message, albeit through different methods of communication. Magic metas were more easily reached via sending spells, whereas the tech ones were never too far from an encrypted email. For the more mundane metas like Thuggernaut, a special Indigo Technologies phone with enhanced security was enough to deliver simple messages of when to arrive. The real information was always doled out in person.

Without warning, the television of their breakroom flickered on, just as they knew every other screen throughout the guild had. Broadcasting these sorts of messages was out of the question, but closed-circuit wiring on their

island made the dissemination of information far more efficient than gathering everyone in a single space. Safer, too.

Doctor Mechaniacal's voice played as images flashed onto the screen: images of space, dotted by an abundance of twisted ships. "Recently, the guild has discovered an extraterrestrial force moving toward Earth. Based on information obtained from our own off-world sources, these are a people called the Wrexwren, a violent, warring culture who we should expect to arrive aggressively."

The room they'd ended up in wasn't especially full—perhaps five other villains milled about as the message played. Uniformly, they paid more attention to the screen with each passing word. Stasis, Johnny Three Dicks, and Thuggernaut were no exception. Idle curiosity warped into genuine interest; with that simple introduction, the guild was hanging on every one of Doctor Mechaniacal's words.

"It is our estimation that the AHC will attempt to conduct a duel to halt the advance. We also expect the Wrexwrens to lie, cheat, or otherwise work around whatever agreement is struck. There is a high possibility that they will mount some type of terrestrial offensive, attempting to split the AHC's focus between the sky and the ground."

In another place, Stasis imagined the words would find a very different reaction. Fear, most likely, as even the most faithful among the capes would feel a trickle of terror at the idea of aliens attacking the planet again. Earth had triumphed over every past invasion, but the wins hadn't all come easily. Anxiety could be reasonably expected, at the very least, worry over what would happen to one's family or property; even in victory, these battles had a cost.

None of that was reflected in her fellow guild members, however. Greed, excitement, even outright bloodlust, *those* were the reactions of villains to this news. Because they understood what Doctor Mechaniacal was really saying. An invading force wasn't just a threat to the planet, it was fair game to play with. For all the effort the capes put into keeping the world safe, they weren't going to complain if aliens trying to conquer it suddenly started dying in droves. There would be ships to loot, weapons to gather, and no shortage of targets for all manner of built-up anger and aggression.

This wasn't a warning. It was notice so they could be prepared to live that day to its fullest. Deep down, Stasis almost felt a flicker of sadness for

these Wrexwren. The dumb fucks really had no idea what kind of planet they'd be stepping onto.

"All interested parties should contact their council representative for more information. We'll have various travel networks in place on the day of, depositing guild members onto scenes as they become active. Standard guild fees apply."

With that, the screen went black once more. Johnny's eyes were already gleaming; Stasis could all but hear the clatter of coins smacking into each other as he rubbed his hands together. "Aliens, capes, and combat—oh my. What entertaining bets I'm going to see on this one."

Thuggernaut's reaction was more subdued, and worrying. The big man closed his meaty fist a single time, squeezing it tightly. "It's been a while since I got a real match in. I wonder how strong they are."

That was something they'd definitely be finding out; Stasis had little doubt there. With Doc getting everyone prepped and the guild handling the transportation, the villains would be incredibly mobile by the time their visitors arrived. No matter where the aliens set down, they'd soon find themselves beset not just by the planet's defenders, but by its demons. After being dragged into the light and forced out of Ridge City, the entire guild was spoiling to throw a punch. There was no chance they'd be able to hold back once they finally had a viable target.

She tossed an elbow into Thuggernaut's side—the only way to get his attention given his overall bulk. "I'm sure the opera is great and all, but it can't compete with an alien invasion."

"Depends on the opera—and the aliens, I'd expect," Thuggernaut shot back. There was no mistaking the fire in his eyes, though. He was excited. "Perhaps I'll book some training sessions, just to make sure I'm not rusty. If they've crossed light years to see our planet, only seems polite to show them our very best efforts."

"Last time he talked like that, we had to haul people to the hospital in a garbage truck. Count me in." Johnny had a notebook he'd produced from a pocket in hand and was already scrawling rapidly into it. "We can have one of the homebodies run the betting board. I'm not missing my chance at some fun."

It was the same throughout the room, and likely the guild as a whole. The idea of bloodshed should have had them concerned, but that was why they were here in the first place. This was not an organization of petty

criminals and simple ruffians. It was a home of villains, beings defined by their power and ambitions. They didn't see a threat; they saw a challenge, a chance to test themselves against invaders from another world.

When the Wrexwren arrived, they would find the guild ready, waiting, and above all else, burning for a fight.

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## Chapter 68

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As the final Starscout meeting before the weekend's End of Summer Shindig, the evening served largely as one last preparation session for the children as well as their cluster leaders. The kids were finishing up banners, signs, and other craft projects that would hang alongside the other clusters' work, marking their respective areas. Ivan was manning the kitchen while simultaneously running through a checklist of items to make sure everyone packed and surreptitiously making notes on the ones he knew at least a few of the kids would forget. He'd already cooked enough treats and snacks to keep them fed on a weeklong march; Tori was almost certain there would be some sort of magic at work to fit it all in his car on the drive up.

Helen appeared to have settled on guiding the kids and messing with Ivan as her main trip-planning tactics. To her credit, she was excellent at both, helping the scouts stay on task while calling out that Ivan had skipped ridiculous items such as inflatable bounce houses and standing sleeping bags. If it annoyed him, he was hiding it from the room, though Tori was fairly sure he didn't mind. Ivan wasn't a terribly expressive person—perhaps that was why she and her mentor understood one another as well as they did. It almost seemed like he was enjoying Helen's teasing, which was possible. They were both single adults and perfectly entitled to flirt, though she'd be surprised to see Ivan on a date. One more person to keep secrets from didn't seem like it would be that appealing to him.

Tori herself was mostly filling in where needed: grabbing more supplies for the kids, cleaning up small messes before they became big ones, generally working support for the enterprise as a whole. She dropped a

fresh bottle of glue next to Beth and Armand, who were teaming up on a particularly intricate glitter-star on the cluster's sign, noting that Ivan's daughter whispered, "Thanks," even in the midst of her work. The more Tori saw of Beth, the fonder she became. All of the kids were growing on her, though she was still quite happy when the meetings came to an end. Fondness or no, Tori only had so much energy to give.

"Hey, Tori, heads up! One for the trash." Helen called the warning before she tossed over an empty tube of paint, which Tori snatched from the air. "Nice! Someone's got the kvizblork tonight."

The tube of paint almost slipped from Tori's firm grasp in surprise. "Did you just quote *The Sashay of Gelzork*?" There was no way she'd heard that right; it was *much* too deep of a cut, even for someone else who liked foreign flicks. Tori's uncertainty lasted only until she finished tossing away the tube and caught the wide-eyed glee in Helen's reaction.

"You got that? Hot dog, nobody else I know digs into the Omdilbom section on Multerion." The excitement brimming from Helen was one Tori was almost embarrassingly familiar with; it was the energy of someone with a secret passion who'd finally found an outlet. "Did you watch any of the Kaldesian octology, or *Finding the Tesseract*?"

At Helen's feet, a curious face turned from the sheet of construction paper and up to the cluster leader. "What are you talking about?" Caden always looked a tad confused, but now, his forehead was positively scrunched.

"We're talking about movies," Helen explained. "Movies from other planets and cultures found across the broad array of alternate universes. Multerion is a service that collects and exports the greatest artistic achievements in film, ones that reoccurred over and over in various verses. Works of high art, meant to be shared with more than just the world that created them."

At Caden's side, Mallory leaned over, whispering with the trademark loudness of a child. "She means movies with subtitles."

"Oh." With that, the entirety of Caden's interest fled, his face turning back to the construction paper, utterly exiting the conversation.

"They don't *all* have subtitles." Helen seemed more to be grumbling to herself than the kids. "A lot of them are from worlds that look and sound like ours."

Loud noises from the kitchen signaled Ivan's emergence with a tray of steaming cookies. Most of these would be saved for the trip, though a few were fated to be consumed by the current swarm of children. Such was the tithe for baking around them. Noting the already hungry stares, Helen snapped into motion so the sweets would have time to cool.

"Okay, everyone, let's take a crafting break." Helen managed to pull both their attention and their silence with a calm voice, a talent that untold teachers would have killed to steal. "Find a good stopping point. It's time to stretch those legs for a bit. If you'll all follow me into the backyard, we can review our weekend events and make sure no one has questions, then play some practice rounds so everyone is comfortable. By the time we're done, I suspect Mr. Gerhardt's cookies will be ready. Tori, could you come with and give me a hand?"

Having seen where this was headed, Tori was already moving for Helen's side. Across the room, Ivan was scooping the cookies onto a wire cooling rack, cutting down on the amount of time they'd have to buy. He looked over to Helen, and it almost seemed as if a smile was trying to force its way onto his face. Instead, it warped into words as he called over to them. "Should I presume you'd like me to hold one back for you?"

"Utah, gimme two." Helen bumped Tori with her shoulder, the shine of expectation nearly glowing on her.

Might as well come clean, rather than drag this out and cause more disappointment. "Um, I haven't really gone through everything yet. Mostly just the sci-fi ones." Tori braced for Helen to be disappointed; instead, she was treated to a grown woman actually clapping her hands together in excitement.

"Hang on. You haven't even seen... wow. Wow. So many amazing things to show you." A rowdy swell of noise from the kids brought her back to the moment at hand. "Later. Things to show you later. For now, let's get out there and do our best. After this, the next time we get together is for the drive on Friday. Make sure you feel ready."

The scent of cookies still hung heavy as they herded the kids out into the night air, which was just cool enough that a bonfire would be perfect once the weekend rolled around. So far as Tori could tell, the kids seemed pretty prepared. No new cluster members meant they'd all been to at least one of these before, and Helen had been adamant about ensuring that every

child knew what to expect. Maybe it was a safety issue, so that if anything did suddenly go off-kilter, the kids would be wise to it.

Such security was obviously unnecessary, not that Tori held it against Helen. The woman had no way of knowing that her supposed cookie-slinger was a nigh-unstoppable force of destruction, one that would do anything to keep his daughter safe. Sometimes, seeing him in that apron, Tori had to remind herself about who else Ivan was. That was what made his cover so perfect, and so powerful. Even the New Science Sentries, when trying to solve the mystery of Fornax, had tossed off any notion that he would live a simple, human life.

That party had been a clear reminder of the stakes at play where secret identities were concerned, reinforcing the importance of that separation. Tori's main goal for the End of Summer Shindig was for nothing out of the ordinary to occur. Barring that, her primary focus would be on keeping the kids safe and protecting Ivan's secret. Because if something *did* come to cause trouble, there was no way Ivan wouldn't stop it, very possibly exposing his secret in the process. Crazy as the worry was, Tori couldn't shake it—not when she knew the consequences. Fornax might not have warrants out anymore, but Ivan would never have his normal life back if the truth came out. No more regular job in middle management, no more blending in, and definitely no leading a Starscout cluster.

Although, part of Tori *would* have liked to see the look on Lodestar's face if she ever found out that Fornax, of all people, had worn the uniform of a cluster leader.



Beverly changed the pattern, watching as the computer loaded a new design onto the digital model, then frowned. Still too busy. She needed something that would tell the owner at a glance what was the front versus the back of the purse, yet wasn't so gaudy the buyers would be ashamed to carry them.

It was possible that Beverly was being more critical than she needed to be out of nerves, trying to keep her mind off the coming visitor. Though she hadn't taken Chloe up on the private room, she had elected to have the meeting at Ridge City Roasters. Despite the late hour, her corner of the



room was oddly unoccupied, something she attributed to Chloe managing even from behind the counter.

The moment Ambrose walked in, she knew it. Not many fellows cast a shadow that tall and wide, or carried themselves with his level of confidence. Ambrose looked like what Beverly had thought of as a cape growing up: big, strong, and with a pronounced chin. It was hardly surprising she'd made that association, either. As her biggest brother, Ambrose had been her hero before she even knew what capes were.

He opened his arms to hug her, then suddenly lost a step. At sight, they'd been overtaken by familiarity, but now the awkwardness of their situation had returned full-force. Beverly ignored the hesitation, barreling in and hugging her brother tightly. Seconds later, he returned the gesture, until they finally parted and hunkered down at the table.

"You look well," Ambrose observed. "Managing to deal with roommates so far?"

"Compared to all the family coming and going at our house? I might as well be living at a spa, it's so peaceful."

The start of a frown tugged at his lips. "Not how I'd categorize having a roommate become national news." It seemed they weren't going to avoid the main topics up front; Ambrose was diving right in.

"Because that was obviously *her* fault." Even Beverly was surprised by the venom in her voice. She was sick of the bullshit Tori had been dealing with just from the sidelines.

Ambrose was momentarily taken aback, though he soon gathered himself. "Right, of course not. I just meant it could potentially be dangerous. No one's fault, only the situation as it stands."

Beverly leaned in, glad for an excuse to cut past the pretense. "Dangerous for who, exactly? Are you scared some kidnappers are going to come calling in the middle of the night? And then what? You know guns don't work, and I've learned more tricks since then."

"That is *precisely* what I was afraid of." Ambrose rubbed the back of his neck, where a small scar from rogue shrapnel still acted up when he got stressed. "You've been experimenting with it? I understand you had to get control, but pushing further is too risky. What if you get stuck that way, or start to lose your sense of self? That monster is scary as hell with you in the driver's seat. I don't want to imagine it running wild."

“Then your advice would be to ignore that I even have this power at all, keep it locked up for the rest of my life?” Beverly demanded.

“Only if getting rid of it entirely isn’t an option.” In contrast to the words, Ambrose’s tone was gentle. It was plain to see that this was all coming from concern for his sister, which at least made it more palatable. “You’re messing with magic you know nothing about, except that you found it in Gran’s collection of junk. If you want to be stronger, we can get you there. Without magic, without powers, without anything even remotely connected to those fucking capes.”

The last bit came out harsher, but Ambrose didn’t slow down. “That’s the biggest fear around the house, you know. That one day, we’ll turn on the screen and see you out there, wearing the outfit, serving that piece of shit and his organization.”

Beverly’s hand landed firmly on Ambrose’s, squeezing it tight. “Look: nobody, me included, knows where my life is heading right now. This was a curveball that I was in no way braced for, but I’m not going to pretend it didn’t happen. I have these powers. Maybe I’ll choose not to use them; maybe I’ll find a good outlet. Either way, I have to face what I am to get past this. That said, the one thing you will *never* have to worry about is me working for Professor Quantum. If I get within punching distance of that motherfucker, you better believe he’s going to be seeing green. Scaly green and fist-shaped, to be precise.”

“Not exactly what the family was hoping to hear, but it’s an excellent starting point.” Ambrose laid his other hand on top of hers, creating a hand sandwich, and pressed it between his. “I suppose the next step is for you to tell me about these ‘tricks’ you’ve been working on.”

“Aren’t you worried that asking me about it might come off as encouragement?”

This time, there was nothing muted about Ambrose’s expression; he broke into a smile that lit his whole face. “Speaking as a representative of the family, it’s a necessary risk for bonding. But speaking as your big brother, I might be coaxed to admit that dragon-shifting powers *do* seem pretty cool. Enough to warrant at least a few questions, and a bit of subtle encouragement.”

Ambrose winked, and Beverly closed her laptop. It was starting to look like she’d want to be here for a while.

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## Chapter 69

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The hurdle shot up from the ground, moving so fast no normal person could have reacted in time. Kyle swung wide with ease, his enhanced sense of time rendering the surprise in slow motion. Touching a few sections of his new bracer, he altered the setlium output slightly, dropping his speed. Professor Quantum didn't permit the same failures twice. In his eyes, a piece of tech failing meant it needed to be refined, situation be damned. It was part of his philosophy as a whole: improve upon what worked, cast aside everything else.

In this case, the new bracer had an updated interface allowing for easier control, reinforced construction to make it harder to break, and it now sent an emergency signal to stabilize the output if it was damaged or disconnected. Next time a villain targeted the bracer, even if they succeeded in disabling it, Tachyonic wouldn't spin out of control. It would be nice to feel as sure about his own capabilities.

As he ducked under a spray of darts, Kyle felt the suit shift with him, flooding his body with high amounts of setlium radiation. He was supposedly lucky, according to Professor Quantum. Not many metas could handle a technique like this; their cells wouldn't drink it in the way his did. This level of augmentation was possible only thanks to that unique talent. Even Austin and Professor Quantum couldn't amplify themselves this way. Then again, they also didn't require the extra help. They were strong enough to hold their own without the need for supplemental tools.

It was an old sore spot in his ego, one that Kyle would consistently feel like he'd moved past, only to be knocked back into it sooner or later. He

wasn't enough without the external help. All the others, even Ike, were on the team under their own power. Kyle alone needed the boost to stand alongside them. And this was a victory; there had been a time he didn't think he'd make the cut. That was why he *had* to be better—at the job, at supporting his team, all of it. Kyle had to prove he belonged there, that he wasn't just Austin's plus one, brought on out of friendship more than talent.

Zippering through an off-ramp, Kyle left the training track, blurring into the waiting room where Austin was doing push-ups. "Can you not let me catch up for a moment before you go off training on your own?"

"No can do. That Bahamut fight was tough as hell. I'm not sure I could have won if it had gone the distance. That means my only option is to get stronger for next time."

About what Kyle had expected. It had been some while since Austin lost to anyone outside an established cape. Going against a real opponent had gotten him stirred up. There was a renewed fire, spurred on by the reminder of how much room there still was to grow. Not beating Lodestar was one thing; having some random crook hold their own against him was a different matter entirely.

Flexing his right hand, Kyle checked the bracer functions while it cooled down, his suit no longer crackling with energy. As it changed, his senses slowed—never quite down to human levels, but nowhere near what he could do in peak Tachyonic form. "The new model is working fine. Going to take a while to get used to, so I'll log some extra training hours when I can."

With a look to the track, Kyle's mind flashed to their practice chambers on Vomisa. "Might swing by the island once I'm feeling more stable. The facilities here aren't quite as challenging as what I'm used to."

"There's nothing wrong with training that doesn't put you at risk of bodily harm." Austin finished his push-up set, rising to his feet. "You looked good out there, didn't seem to be missing a step. How do you feel?"

"Stupid, mostly," Kyle admitted. "I can't believe I got my bracer cracked by some asshole already."

The heavy hand patting Kyle on the back was familiar, annoying, and unprotested. "I think you're being hard on yourself. You say 'some asshole,' but those two were meta-humans with training and preparation, ones who've squared off with capes before. Donald's team suspects they're

connected to that guild of villains. Not the sort of enemy easily brushed aside.”

All of which was true, but Austin was skipping over the fact that everyone else had at worst been handed a draw. There was no denying that Tachyonic had lost. He knew there had been fallout from Professor Quantum, and that Austin was probably shielding him from it, which only made the guilt he felt over failing all the worse.

That wasn’t something an apology was going to fix, however. The only course Kyle had was to improve. Get better, stronger, and hell yes, faster, so that when the next bout came, he’d be an asset rather than a fuckup Austin had to take heat for.

“Next time I see Hephaestus, he won’t get the chance to surprise me.” Heat rose in his cheeks, his mind flitting back to the after-incident report they’d been given. “I can’t believe there aren’t warrants for those bastards.”

Another few pats, though these were more subdued. “The law is the law, and ultimately, there was never any proof they were committing a crime. I wish we hadn’t ended up being their alibi, though.” Austin had been the first to learn about the slaughter in the same town where they’d been fighting, and he’d quickly passed it on to the others. Whatever happened in that blood-drenched place, Hephaestus and Bahamut couldn’t have been present. All meta-forensics indicated it was still going on when the New Science Sentries were on the scene.

“They’re smart.” Kyle tapped a few more buttons, finishing off the cool-down cycle on his suit. Donald and Ren had recounted the way Hephaestus used the law against them. Whoever that crook was, he came at unexpected angles. “We’ll have to be smarter.”

“For the moment, I’ll just be happy when you’re back at full power,” Austin said, steering them away from the topic of vengeance. “I never feel comfortable without you watching my back.”

One last shake of the arm to make sure everything was holding well, and Kyle fully powered off the bracer. This was the third test, and so far, there hadn’t been any glitches. The new unit was working just fine. Time to take it out of the lab and make sure it could handle the actual work.

“In that case, buzz the team and go grab a mask. I think it’s time to put this baby through its paces.”



“You’ll pay us to... cause trouble.” To look at Edna, one would form some fast opinions based on her appearance. Being a burly meta meant she had a tall, muscular frame. Unfortunately, some of the side effects of her condition included a receding hairline and unnaturally colored acne. By modern standards of beauty, she wouldn’t be winning any hearts. Not that it mattered; Edna wasn’t running things because of her looks, or even her strength. She had a keen eye for details and a gut that never steered her wrong—that was why the others trusted her.

At the moment, that gut was screaming that this guy was trouble, same as it had when Balaam came calling. The sorcerer had seen her people as nothing more than cannon fodder, and Edna knew what happened to fodder in a battle. This gentleman was making a more enticing pitch, yet she still kept her guard up.

“That is correct,” Wendel Worthington replied. He was stoic, only smiling thinly at any attempts toward levity or ice-breaking. There something about his eyes that set Edna’s nerves buzzing: twin voids lacking any sort of human connection. “Specifically, to cause trouble at a time and general geographic area of my choosing. Transportation can be arranged, or you may handle it with your own resources, if security is a concern.”

“My concern is not security.” Edna pointed a thick finger up to the restaurant’s tastefully painted ceiling. In this private room, it displayed a lovely design of interwoven circles. “My concern is the people who zip around through the sky, smacking the shit out of any crime they spot. We lay low, Mr. Worthington. Stay off the radar of the big fish. What you’re proposing sounds a lot like the riots that got so many people tossed in jail a few months ago.”

At that, Wendel bristled. “Certainly not. Balaam’s hubris allowed him to think he could actually win, which is preposterous. This is merely a strike during a window of opportunity. I happen to have it on good authority that there will soon come a day in which all of the major capes are occupied. When that time arrives, those with forewarning will be able to pounce, taking advantage of their distraction. However, there are always new members of the AHC joining, and I’d prefer to work uninterrupted. Your job would be to help cause enough mayhem that the remaining forces are scattered. Should a cape close in on your particular position, feel free to escape. Reach that point, or make it until the end; I’ll consider the job accomplished, regardless.”

The offer to run made it more enticing—Edna never went into any situation without an exit strategy. From the trolley of food sitting at the side of their table, she pulled off a rib and bit into it, bone and all. It was a trick she'd picked up initially for negotiation intimidation, but was also a handy way to get at the tasty marrow within. Seeing as Wendel was bothering to butter her up at a nice restaurant, she might as well enjoy it.

“How big of an area are we talking? A city, a block? How much room do I have to work in? Some of those capes can close in awfully fast.”

There it was, that thin smile, like he was afraid to stretch his mouth. “A fine question. You will be given an area of roughly ten square miles within a major metropolis. Ample space to select targets, as well as adequate cover should escape or concealment be necessary. Also large enough that, were you afraid I was laying some sort of trap, the area would be much too large for an ambush.”

“Depends on how many forces you brought.” Edna didn't really believe her own words; she knew her gang wasn't high enough on the food chain to warrant such effort. If they pissed off someone truly dangerous, they'd be butchered where they stood. Traps were laid for tougher prey. “But ten square miles of city isn't bad. That's about four football fields' worth of stuff, and in an urban environment, it'll be packed with options.” Since Wendel only wanted chaos, Edna wouldn't even have to mess with well-defended targets like banks or stores. She could focus her people's efforts on activities that were flashy, with minimal risk of capture. Hit hard, steal a little extra, then escape before things got too hot.

In front of Wendel sat only a single cup, filled with hot tea. He lifted the drink from the saucer and touched it briefly to his mouth. Edna wasn't completely sure she'd seen him imbibe or ingest a single bit of their meal together. Not the strangest thing, perhaps. Different cultures had different attitudes toward eating in public, and more than a few meta-humans were self-conscious about how they looked while dining. He could have just said that, though. It was the seeming pretense, the pretending to drink, that put her on edge. Between that, the smile, and those damned eyes, Edna felt very much like she was across from something playing at being human.

Issues aside, what he was pitching might indeed be lucrative. Based on the few details being doled out, Edna could guess he'd made a similar pitch to other outfits, with more to come. A game like this relied on numbers; Wendel wanted enough noise to drown out whatever he was planning. That

meant there would be plenty of people causing trouble, and her team, ideally, would not stand out. So long as they came at it smart, picked the right targets to avoid pulling in any capes or cops, it should be possible to do the job, get the money, and avoid ending up in a cold cell. They were going to be ready to run, though; this was not a situation where Edna wanted to overextend.

“Assuming the details line up with what we can manage, I think this could be a working arrangement.” Edna was careful to leave herself an out, just in case. People like this didn’t react well to plans changing, but there was no way she was giving total commitment until everything was settled.

“I am glad to hear it, and I have faith we’ll be able to come to terms on the minor matters.” Wendel lifted his cup once more, only this time, there was no thin smile waiting. At last, those lips truly parted, revealing teeth that were artificially white, then kept on stretching, well past the point of good taste.

Now, Edna understood why Wendel kept his face so neutral. When it twisted in emotion, the wrongness of it all could be seen. Something off, inhuman, in the way that mouth kept growing, revealing more and more of those near glowing teeth. He lifted the cup higher, making a short cheers.

“To new business.” She watched as he tossed the tea down his throat, not even reacting to the steaming liquid splashing against tender mouth-flesh.

With great effort, Edna kept a tremor of fear from making it to her hands as she lifted her own glass of water. Under that watchful dark eye and hideous smile, she drank, already wondering if this was all a terrible mistake.



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## Chapter 70

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It was a meeting that complicated things. Originally, the plan had been simple. Ivan would leave work a few hours early—with permission, of course—to go pick up Beth. He'd then circle back to scoop up Tori as her day was finishing, bringing both of them to the meeting point. There, they would join the rest of the cluster on a rented bus that would take them to the End of Summer Shindig. Slightly inefficient, but it minimized the amount of potential crossover between his lives.

Unfortunately, once Danny from marketing got on a roll, he could run for quite a while. That had turned what was supposed to be a simple spec meeting into a brainstorming session for new features and ideas, none of which would ultimately be implemented. Losing time was bad enough; losing it to pointless ego would have put Ivan in a foul mood under different circumstances. Faced with the prospect of a weekend spent bonding with his daughter, though, Ivan's temperament was softer than usual. It was hard to be mad when something so wonderful was on the horizon.

A positive outlook didn't solve the issue, however. That honor had fallen to Ivan's pragmatism, which quickly outlined the easiest solution to stay on schedule. He could either send Tori in one of the guild cars, or bring her along to pick up Beth. Except, Tori arriving separately would invite needless questions, since he and Beth had already gone over their existing travel plans. It would probably be a small matter to explain them away, but Ivan's recent experience with Rick was an excellent reminder that minor inconsistencies added up over time. The fewer questions asked, the fewer answers sought.

“You okay? If I didn’t know better, I’d say you were nervous.” Tori had largely been staring out the window as they made their way across Ridge City to Janet’s home. Something must have caught her attention, as she’d shifted her focus to Ivan. He didn’t feel as if he was showing the stress that badly, which meant he either wasn’t hiding it as well as he thought or Tori was getting better at reading him. Not a huge surprise—they were similar people who spent large amounts of time together—but also not a development Ivan was fully comfortable with.

The drive to Janet’s was rote after so many years; Ivan may as well have been one of Wade’s bots for all the mental effort it demanded to take the proper highway exit, plunging them into the outlands of suburbia. Ivan had been debating how much to tell Tori. He didn’t want to color her perceptions needlessly, but if she’d picked up on his energy, then forewarned was likely the best strategy. “There is a chance you’ll meet my ex-wife today. She’s working from home, so depending on whether or not she’s on a call when we arrive, Janet may come out to bid Beth farewell.”

He watched surprise morph to curiosity, then continue its evolution to speculation, all in a single brown-eyed blink from Tori. There was no guessing what sorts of images she’d conjured for the former Mrs. Fornax, save only that all of them were wrong. Nobody ever saw Janet coming—it was part of what made her all the more dangerous.

“Anything particular I should know going in?” A sudden sheen of fear washed over her face. “Oh shit, wait, what does she think our relationship is? Did she get the uncle story, or is it like with the kids, and I should stick to just being coworkers?”

A perfectly reasonable question, one that nevertheless pained Ivan to answer. He’d had to read Janet in on Tori at the start. She needed to know the cover story, and deserved forewarning about potential threats to the family, had Tori turned out to be that particular brand of evil. It still felt like a small betrayal to have given away part of Tori’s secret to someone else.

“She knows you’re part of the guild. I never went into specifics on powers or the like, but Janet is aware of our real connection.”

“Yeeesh. Couldn’t you just have said I was some prospect with a shitload of potential that the company would be eternally lesser without?”

Ivan cocked an eyebrow. “Eternally lesser?”

“I’ll have you know that I’m the one who reformatted the meeting request form. You think that bad boy shrank two pages on its own?” Tori

rapped her knuckles against the dash, putting extra punctuation on her next words. “Eternally. Lesser.”

“Don’t get too carried away. If you remove all the bottlenecks and slow-downs, people will realize management doesn’t actually do anything.”

Affecting a solemn nod, Tori appeared to consider this revelation. “You’re right. I can’t go down that road. Getting rid of middle management is more a cape move than a villain one. I guess I should... add more hurdles?”

“That’s called working toward a promotion.” Ivan’s mood brightened as he turned down a familiar lane. Anxious as he was about the potential collision of worlds, the worry was having a hard time overtaking his excitement for the weekend ahead.

They pulled into the driveway and Ivan killed the engine, reaching for his seatbelt. By the time it was unclicked, he could see the figure walking out the front door. Part of him had hoped Beth would be waiting, so eager for the trip she’d come bursting from the house with bags in hand. Sadly, the figure was much too tall to be Beth, though it perhaps did offer some insight into the height she could one day inherit. Janet was dressed for work—matching jacket and skirt atop a pressed shirt, even though nobody was around to see it. That was just her, one of the eccentricities Ivan had acclimated to in their marriage. It wasn’t as if he’d had any room to throw stones.

Her finger rapped against the passenger window, startling Tori slightly. With one glance to Ivan for confirmation, which he gave, she rolled down the window, allowing Janet to speak.

“Beth couldn’t find her phone charger. She’s hunting around for it.” Now that the partition was no longer between them, Janet gave Tori a more thorough examination, adjusting her glasses midway through. “You must be Tori, the one who’s been helping out with the cluster. Pleasure to meet you.”

Through the open window, they shook hands, Janet continuing to stare. “You, as well. Ivan’s told me such nice things about you.”

“No, he hasn’t. He’s been respectful, but also made it clear I’m a pain in the ass.” Janet finished shaking Tori’s hand, releasing unceremoniously. “I have to live most of my life lying, thanks to Ivan’s past, so let’s dispense with it where unneeded.”

Brusque, though Tori was hard-pressed to say it was inaccurate. Hiding a major villain as a husband, ex or current, was bound to be a complicated

matter. She was having enough trouble keeping her own identity secret, and that was without anywhere near the fame of Fornax.

“It keeps things simpler, anyway. Look at it this way: if I weren’t in the know, there’s really only one believable cover to use when a middle-aged man pulls up to his ex’s house with a younger woman.”

“*Janet!*” Ivan hissed, while Tori felt a small bit of blood rise to her face.

She paid little attention to either, most of her focus remaining on the door. “Relax. We already established I’m aware that’s not the case. The lie wouldn’t work, anyway. I know it’s not the younger ones who catch your fancy.”

This time, there was nothing subtle about the blush, as Tori realized she was getting back-scenes extras on this relationship that she very much did not want to know. Deciding that it was better to jump into the awkwardness than sit through whatever it was this was heading, Tori spat the first words that leapt to her mind.

“How did you two crazy kids meet in the first place? I’m guessing it wasn’t sharing a soda down at the malt shop.” This was something she’d been sincerely wondering for a while. The settling down part made sense because of Rick, but how did a super-villain and a normal person end up dating to start with?

The response wasn’t immediate. For an instant, Janet looked up to Ivan, and a flicker of the past flashed between them. “Stupidity, youth, and adrenaline. I was going through a rebellious phase, taking up at bars without the safest of reputations. One night, a gang decided they’d like to help themselves to the till, regardless of what the bar’s owners thought. Came in with guns drawn, screaming orders, even shoved a pistol into the face of a patron.” The wistfulness died as Janet shook her head. “When Ivan ripped the forearm from the elbow, gun still in hand, I wasn’t sure if the bar was screaming more in horror or surprise. But watching him savage those robbers... well, if I were making smart choices at the time, I wouldn’t have been there at all. There was something appealing about a man that capable.”

Having seen Ivan go into Fornax mode, Tori wasn’t sure “appealing” was the categorization she would use, but clearly she and Janet had different tastes. The story tracked—a situation like that was bound to stir someone up. The effects of adrenaline on libido were well documented. It didn’t fully explain Ivan’s side of things, but then again, Tori had never known Ivan in his Fornax days. Janet was a striking woman. If that version

of Ivan was more open to socializing, she'd certainly have been able to turn his head.

"Mind you, decades later, my kids are going to be stuck at a new school while theirs is getting rebuilt, because one of Ivan's supposed allies blew it up. So take a lesson here, Tori. Don't hook up over bloodshed. It doesn't lead to the wisest of choices."

Not wanting to touch the vast majority of that topic, Tori steered into the one bit she could comment on. "It's a shame about the school. Looked like a pretty nice place."

"How do you know—?" The flash of understanding in her eyes came without warning. Immediately, Tori watched Janet's entire demeanor shift. She didn't lose the stiff spine or set chin, but the rest of her expression softened noticeably. "You're the one."

"I'm the one?" Tori was accustomed to hearing those words with a tone of accusation, not gratitude, momentarily blinding her to the obvious truth.

The hand was so unexpected, Tori almost jerked back before it landed lightly on her shoulder. Janet held her there, making uncomfortably direct eye contact. "Thank you, Tori, or whatever your name is while in that suit. Thank you for being the only person in that fucking guild who cared enough to go protect my children."

It wasn't fair; the others hadn't even realized Rick and Beth were being targeted. Tori had only gotten the information because she beat it out of Rust Tooth when he tried to kill her. Knowing all of that versus being able to communicate it at the time were different matters, and Janet didn't seem to be inclined toward listening where the guild was involved. Ivan could clear things up, if it mattered. Tori was just trying to get through this.

"Given the, uh, delicate situation, I, um, can neither confirm nor deny anything, ma'am." That earned her a laugh from Janet, a gentler sound than Tori would have predicted.

"I can see why Wade paired you two up. That's fine, Tori. You don't need to say a word. Just know I'm grateful. Whatever else is going on in your life, you put yourself in harm's way to protect my kids. That's not the sort of thing I'm going to forget." Janet released her grip, casting a glance back at the door. "Do your best to keep everyone out of trouble this weekend, if you can."

Tori nodded, grateful to be back on semi-normal conversational ground. "Nothing to worry about. Between all of Helen's planning and Ivan being

Ivan, these kids are in excellent hands.”

Outside of people she knew quite well, Tori didn't have much talent for reading emotions, which spoke to just how naked the vitriol on Janet's face was at the mention of the name “Helen.” Had Tori not just been outed as the one who helped Beth and Rick, she had a hunch Janet would be letting loose some unfriendly sentiments. Instead, the expression was forced away slowly, moved by willpower rather than feeling more at ease.

“I'm sure they'll be well cared for. Just don't want anyone to get distracted.”

A bang from the front door pulled everyone's attention to Beth, who was zipping along with a white cord clutched in her hands. “Found it!”

Like a magic trick, stern Janet vanished into a haze of affection as she swept her daughter up. Gone were the harsh expressions and scrutinizing stares, replaced by a loving mother bidding her child farewell.

Perhaps it was from being rattled by the meeting, or the sight of a girl wearing a Starscout uniform being held by her mom, but Tori had to look away. It came a little too close to memories of her own, as well as the ones she'd been denied. Tori had never gotten to have a moment like this. Her parents were both dead long before she'd reached Beth's age.

When the farewell was finished, Ivan tossed Beth's bag into the trunk, loading the girl herself into the back seat of the car moments after. Janet lingered in the yard, waving goodbye until she was no longer visible in the rearview mirror. It had been an awkward start, but with that out of the way, Ivan and Tori were hoping for a fun, non-meta-human weekend.

That alone should have tipped them off to the chaos looming on the horizon.

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## Chapter 71

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Huge fangs, dripping in what was probably acid or venom. A massive, scaly body covered in spines and sharp edges. Three tails slapping about wildly, making any approach from the back or side difficult, funneling enemies toward that big chomping maw with the dripping teeth. All packed into creatures each roughly the size of a city bus.

Honestly, not much of a challenge, at a cursory glance. It wasn't until Lodestar saw the flash of blue light hit and fizzle away that she understood why Wranglore, the spell-slinging cowboy, had called for backup.

Magic resistance, so these probably weren't mutations or science experiments run amok. Rather, they were some sort of mystical being. Summoned, created, or anything in between, when magic was on the table there were a lot more options. Looking at the silver lining, they were at least fully corporeal. For all her power, Lodestar didn't have very much non-physical versatility. She was largely pure force—anything that could phase enough to not be damaged by energy shots required help from the AHC's own magical resources. The semi-incorporeality was why she'd needed so much help to deal with Orion and was the reason magic users were such a pain for her to handle, in general.

Given that she only had five more minutes before she needed to be at the meeting point; there wasn't enough time to reroute the request for help. She'd just have to hope these beasts were as solid as they looked. From the sky, she dropped, increasing her speed as she went. This was no AHC evaluation; she didn't have to hold back on anything short of lethal force, and that was only until they knew if these creatures were inherently

destructive or simply looking for food. Lodestar's speed cranked up until she could see the world in slow motion.

Wranglore had his hand cocked in a finger-gun, another spell formed at the tip of his index finger, sparking as it fired off. The nearest creature appeared to have noticed and was twisting toward him, mouth already parting. Lodestar saw a chance to test how immune these things really were, as well as help a fellow cape pitch in, so she took it. Grabbing the turning monster by the mouth, she jerked its head and pulled the jaws wider, ensuring that Wranglore's shot would go right down its throat.

That would take some time to connect, so she kept working. Zipping over to the one in front, Lodestar slowed herself down. She had to understand what she was dealing with. Scary on the outside didn't mean bad on the inside; that was a lesson she'd taken far too long to learn.

"Whoa there, big fella. Calm it down. How about you and me—" The words were cut off by a sudden lunge as those huge, dripping fangs came down on top of her. It would have been simple to dodge, yet she elected not to. Instead, she waited as the teeth shattered against her, hammers of clay smashing upon an iron anvil. Since conversation failed, this would tell her the rest of what she needed to know.

It took a moment for the monster to realize it had been defanged. A moan rose from deep in its gut, something hideous, and a spray of that dripping liquid gurgled up along with it. In the last second, Lodestar let out a burst of energy, vaporizing the liquid before it made contact. She wasn't worried about it hurting her, more concerned for how much extra work that would add to cleaning up once this was done. Today was on a particularly tight schedule.

With no teeth and its acid attack failed, Lodestar waited to see what would come next. She sighed as its jaws continued to gum against her and gurgling rose from the stomach, signaling a fresh batch of liquid attack brewing. Silly as it seemed, the action told her quite a bit. This creature was either made for killing or incredibly stubborn. Most animals would stop attacking something they had broken their teeth against, yet this one didn't even have that level of sense. Probably non-sentient, just conjurations made by some meta messing with forces they shouldn't have. Still, she'd play it safe until the experts could give their opinion. Wounds could be healed. There was no taking back death.



Turning the speed back on, Lodestar virtually disappeared from the maw, soaring back into the air. She wasn't there for long, finding the nearest target and dashing right into its mouth, this time breaking the teeth herself. She did a round on the feet, making sure there were no claws to worry about, then finished by tying the three tails tightly together. For some reason, that trick rarely worked on monsters made by science, but magic ones veered closer to cartoon rules. Nobody fully grasped why that distinction existed; it was just one of the many countless mysteries of living in a meta-world.

With a system established, Lodestar grew even faster. She was a flash of light, weaving through the pack, leaving a trail of beaten monsters in her wake. When she made it back around to Wranglore, Lodestar was momentarily confused by the stunned monster with smoke rising from its nose she found near him, before she remembered opening his target's mouth. Evidently, the magic resistance was literally skin-deep. Handy to know if these ever popped up again. Until they found the source, it couldn't be discounted as a possibility.

Wranglore's knockout was the final monster, so Lodestar brought herself back into normal time. Super-speed didn't really tax her to use, but staying in that state for too long eventually made her nauseous. It was a constant mental jarring, expecting things to move at one speed then readjusting on the fly over and over again. Some metas fell in love with the speed, tried to live there for as long as they could, but to her, it was just one more tool in the kit. A useful one, though.

“—that!”

Part of the problem of moving in and out of time perceptions was dropping into conversations already in progress. Given the look on his face, she assumed Wranglore was taunting his recently defeated foe. This also gave Lodestar a front-row seat to Wranglore's face as he took in the rest of the scene. He pushed back the rune-covered cowboy hat on his head, letting out a whistle like he was calling the herd.

“Holy... you tore right on through these things.” Wranglore threw a spurious look at his finger, still letting off a tendril of magical smoke. “I was feeling good about my one.”

“Luck of the draw,” Lodestar said. “They were resistant to magic, not fists. Another enemy, our roles easily could have been reversed.”

She gave the scene one last check, then covertly looked at the watch woven into the underside of her left bracer. “Do you mind holding down this area until cleanup arrives? I’ve got somewhere to be.”

“Seems the very least I can do, since this was my job to start.” Wranglore wiggled his hand, dispelling the last of the smoke. “Thanks for the... assist doesn’t seem like the right word here.”

“Well, it should, because that’s all I did. You uncovered the threat, located it, alerted us to the issue, and called in appropriate force before they could reach civilization. I threw a few punches. Being strong doesn’t mean diddly if I don’t know where to point that strength. You saved the day, Wranglore, and I was happy to pitch in where I could.”

Lodestar didn’t wait around after that; experience taught her it was best to depart on the uplifting statement. It helped leave things on a positive note, and delaying came with fewer graceful conversational off-ramps. That was especially important, because she was down to only two minutes left. Rising into the air, Lodestar flew faster up once more, this time cranking up to traveling speeds.

Technically speaking, the speed at which she was moving through the air should be causing friction and shockwaves, leaving untold destruction in her path. It was one of the more commonly observed curiosities since Professor Quantum broke the original laws of physics in the same legendary experiment that created meta-humans, and one that no one had a viable explanation for: the people with super-speed seemed to ignore all issues of friction. It was the same way that some metas could be so huge, and yet completely skip the square-cube law, or how super-strength translated into lifting cars rather than putting hands right through the metal. Their world was not as it had once been, and even after all these decades, they’d still only scratched the surface on understanding how the new systems worked.

For today, Lodestar was just thankful for whatever made them function as she raced across the ocean, heading back to North America. Getting in and out of the house would be easy thanks to her tunnels, but there wasn’t any need. Since returning to the AHC, she’d been picking up old habits, including one from her street-crime fighting days. Back then, she’d had nests hidden throughout Faucet Hills, places she could stop for supplies and rest. Rest wasn’t much of an issue these days, but a superhero worth her salt always had a few spare outfits around.

Zippering into an abandoned bell tower at a former East Coast college, Lodestar found the hidden silver box. Professor Quantum's creation, these were as secure an option as she had for leaving unattended equipment. Slowing down only long enough to punch in the code, Lodestar waited as the systems engaged, hissing slightly to reveal the box's hidden treasures. Inside were the same clothes Helen had been wearing before she got the call. A blur of light, and Lodestar switched her ensemble, adding the uniform to the contents of the box, next to a spare t-shirt and jeans. Her usual Lodestar garb was packed with the rest of her supplies for the End of Summer Shindig, which is why she'd had to snag the nest's spare on her way. She took one last item from the box—a set of spectacles, though these were held carefully rather than being donned. Pausing to check her makeup once—mercifully, sweat was very rarely an issue in this state—Lodestar took back to the sky.

She raced across the country, until Ridge City came into view. At the sight, she felt her heart lift. It was always good to be home, especially with such a fun weekend to look forward to. Hopefully, the AHC would be okay without Lodestar for a few days. Granted, she could come if she was called, but Lodestar had been burning the candle at both ends since her return. The other side of her deserved some time, too.

It was a matter of seconds before she was at the parking lot, but Lodestar didn't stop there. She kept going, flying a bit farther, then dropping down into one of the nearby alleyways. To be safe, she pulled out a phone-sized device and hit a small icon that flashed red, then green. Every camera in the area was either disabled or scrambled—one of Vernon's handiest inventions, and the reason she kept a Quantum Utility Tool on her. With the coast cleared, Lodestar pulled the power back into her at the same time she donned her spectacles.

Glasses in place, Helen jogged down the alley, weaving her way back to the parking lot. In the middle of the day, at those speeds, the odds that anyone had seen Lodestar arriving were infinitesimal, but it never hurt to be extra cautious. Even given the special identity protections Helen had, she still played it safe where she could. The life of a public cape was not one she wanted, for her or Penelope.

Helen arrived a full three minutes before the bus pulled in, which still beat the earliest time the Starscouts would start showing up by half an hour. After going over details with the driver, she did a quick tour of the vehicle,

eyes peeled for any potential issues, of which she uncovered none. It was a little old and a bit run-down, but they hadn't exactly paid for top-of-the-line luxury. The bus was safe, which mattered most, and she could always stick Ivan in one of the broken seats that didn't recline. Relaxation and Ivan went together like mint and orange juice.

By the time her tour was done, a car was pulling into the lot. Too early for the kids, and besides, she recognized that nondescript sedan, just like she knew the intentionally bland man stepping out of it. He did seem more animated than usual, his resting-stern face replaced by interest in his conversation with Beth. The others in the AHC would probably never see this side of him, would never let themselves see it, even if they had a chance. It was so much easier when the capes were good and the villains were bad. Getting in too close, realizing how much more was at play, understanding that the people they fought were more than their crimes... it made things complicated. Not always bad, but never easy.

Tori was right behind Ivan and Beth, and she threw Helen a grin as they saw one another. Another villain she shouldn't be getting close with. The reports of Hephaestus's conflict with the New Science Sentries had already reached her, as did photographs of the scene that team *didn't* see. For her, it was obvious; Hephaestus had been on lookout duty, keeping the AHC members away from the real show. Horribly, a piece of her was even thankful for it. Helen wasn't sure any of them were experienced enough to handle that kind of scene. At least it had happened on a weekend when Ivan had his kids. It was a small mercy that she didn't have to add his potential presence into the whole confusing equation.

"Good afternoon!" Helen's voice was full of cheer and pep as she greeted her first Starscout of the day. "Is everyone packed and ready for an amazing weekend of fun, friends, and frivolity?"

"Yay!" Beth threw up her arms in celebration, and for a moment, even Ivan's steely demeanor was cracked by a smile.

"A little alliteration?" Tori chuckled at her own wordplay, unintentional though it was. "Yeah, I'd say we're pretty psyched."

Ivan didn't respond immediately; that was never his way. Only in battle was he quick and decisive. In his civilian identity, he favored being steady over being speedy. Better to grasp a situation well, and then act, than move in too rashly. It was one of the traits Helen admired in him; she tended to be prone to impulse in her own life. "Is there anything you need?"

“Sure, take this clipboard and help me greet our cluster as they roll in. We have to get an accurate head count before we can depart.” Helen thrust the hunk of wood into Ivan’s chest, and with it, she saw the nearly imperceptible signs of his nerves easing. What he’d really been asking was if there were threats to be aware of, and she’d just told him to keep his mind on the actual tasks of the job. Ivan did best when he had a role to play and a script to follow. Keeping him in cluster-leader mode would put his focus on actual issues, rather than potential ones.

For the first time since she’d been staring down at the stampeding hoard of monsters, Helen paused and took a breath. There was still a lot of weekend to go, and she hoped not to spend any more of it flying through the air while shining brightly.

“How was your Friday? Soak in the last bits of civilization while you still can?” Tori asked.

Helen half-shrugged, as if her activities were too boring to warrant a proper roll of the shoulders. “Same old, same old. Just another day at the office.”

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## Chapter 72

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In the planning, preparation, and lead-up to this trip, Tori thought she'd gotten a good sense of what she was in for, having never gone to such an event in her own Starscout days. It took only until the bus pulled onto the campgrounds, joining dozens of others streaming onto the site, for Tori to realize just how off her expectations had been.

She'd pictured ten or so other clusters, all sharing a large chunk of forest with perhaps one central cabin in case of emergencies. Instead, Tori was forced to wonder if the entire state was all gathering for this single End of Summer Shindig; she stopped counting after the first fifty buses. Given that the attendance was so much higher than expected, she was somewhat less shocked as they began to weave their way through a huge swath of land. Dotted around it were various cabins and hookup points for RVs, all of which the huge convoy passed, heading into the deepest part of the forest.

It was there she finally saw the Starscout area—what almost looked like someone had built a full summer camp meant for hundreds of people out in the middle of nowhere. There were bunk cabins, a huge mess hall, various activity stands, a lake twinkling in the late-evening sun, and tons of space for setting up tents. Clearly multipurpose, yet she had to imagine this was the zenith of its usefulness, the main intent with which the space was built.

Since summer still held a slight upper hand in the changing of the seasons, it was warm enough to camp outside using tents. Some years, it had to be the bunk cabins for safety, and depending on how the winds blew, that might still end up being the case, but for the first evening, Tori found

herself pitching in to help the scouts set up their camp. Or rather, she tried to do that, but instead discovered that the kids were overall better at it than she was. For them, this was old hat, whereas Tori had never been a fan of tents, even in her street days. Since she didn't worry about the cold, the loss of visibility wasn't worth the minor protection from the elements.

Only once every tent was sturdy and stable did Helen gather her charges. They'd ended up fairly in the middle of things, surrounded by other clusters, not far from the lake. It was a vantage point that showed her the multitude of others still handling their setup, giving Tori an unexpected pang of pride in the efficiency of her group. The sentiment was especially unwarranted given how little she'd helped, yet it was there, all the same. There were, thankfully, logistics to focus on instead.

"Great job setting up!" Helen declared, getting a rabble of cheers from the kids. She didn't let it grow past that, speaking while she had their attention captured. "Time to look ahead to the rest of our evening. We've got about an hour before the mess will start serving dinner, and the social starts right after, so anyone who wants to wash up should get jumping. We all know how fast the lines can grow around here."

The rest of the cluster nodded, so Tori did, as well. It wasn't hard to picture; this many people were going to cause traffic no matter what. She wondered if Ivan had brought along any sort of Wade-tech to mitigate that issue, at least where restrooms were concerned. Unlikely, but a woman could dream.

"Tomorrow, we start the Shindig Games bright and early, so try not to stay up *too* late catching up with your friends." There was something of a wink in her tone, the implied understanding of a rule that must exist, and yet everyone expects to be broken. "Tori and Mr. Gerhardt are our only newbies here. The rest of you know the area. Remember to stay within the camp at all times, unless you're in the company of a Starscout leader—we *are* still in the wilderness. If you need anything, I'll be here. Otherwise, come back by seven for dinner."

It was almost akin to being in a flophouse when someone screamed "Cape!" the way those children scattered. They fled in every direction, racing away from their area, streaming into other camps and calling out greetings. Coming here yearly, they'd obviously made friends among the other clusters, which was probably the point of getting them all together in the first place. Tori wondered if she'd been too young for these kinds of

events, or if her parents had simply been too busy. It was tempting to put them on a pedestal, but keeping them human in her memories also helped make the pain manageable. They'd both been career-driven scientists; it wasn't inconceivable that this sort of thing was more than their schedules could, or would be allowed, to bear.

"Are we sure none of them used magic? That was a really quick departure," Tori noted.

"Our only known magic meta-human at this particular function is Lavinia, who you can thank for the utter lack of insects around us. She's got some handy repelling spells laid down." Helen scanned the campground once, like she was taking note of every activity and not just the actions of their kids. "Since we've got some time to work—Ivan, why don't you finish unloading the rest of our supplies? Get some exercise for a change, you desk-jockey. Tori, we can't have you out here without knowing how to ready a tent, so you're going to help me with mine."

With one hand, Tori waved to the rows of tents already sitting there. "Seems like that's already handled, doesn't it?"

"Until a strong wind knocks one over in the night and a scout needs help fixing it, potentially while terrified from being suddenly woken up. Or when breaking them down happens, and they need your help to not snap a delicate part of the frame. We're the adults here. The kids have to know we can handle any problem that arises. The buck stops with us, so we should be prepared."

On the surface, it might be difficult to see why Helen and Ivan got along so well, despite coming from visibly different worlds. But when one scratched the slightest bit deep, the biggest similarity leapt into view: responsibility. Helen and Ivan both cared a tremendous amount about the duty of their roles; each took their responsibilities arguably *too* seriously. Tori felt reasonably sure the world wouldn't end if she couldn't make a tent, yet from the way Helen spoke, it was like there were incredible stakes at play.

She followed Helen over, taking hold of a faded old green tent and helping to spread it out along the ground. In the corner of her eye, Tori could see Ivan unloading boxes of food from the bus—their contribution to the overall supplies. He almost reached for an entire stack of four, then thought better of it, shifting his grip up to two. Finally, and not without some visible annoyance, Ivan settled on a single box, hefting it onto his



shoulder and starting the trek toward the mess hall. It had to be galling, knowing he could lift the whole bus, and having to do things the mundane way all the same.

A jolt brought Tori back to the moment. Helen had gently tapped the tip of her nose. It was more shocking than painful, jarring her suddenly. “We can help Ivan afterward if you’re worried about him, but there’s no point in doing this unless you’re paying attention.”

“Sorry,” Tori mumbled.

“It’s okay. I get it. New scene, lots to take in—this is an exciting place, and we’re going to have a lot of fun here.” Helen patted the green canvas firmly. “After our chores are done.”

Tori watched carefully as Helen stretched the fabric, pulling out the long tubes of plastic and slowly threading them through loops sewn into the tent. The procedure was smooth and effortless, equally so when Helen yanked them all right back out and set the tubes at Tori’s feet. “Your turn.”

“I just watched you do it.”

“Then it should be easy to replicate,” Helen countered. “And I’ll be here if you run into trouble.”

“For someone only a few years older than me, you sure do like to give orders.” Tori picked up the nearest tube and began attempting to mimic the feat she’d seen Helen so easily manage. It eventually did make it through the first loop, but it wasn’t nearly so smooth an operation.

Reaching over, Helen pinched a piece of fabric, breaking up a minor stoppage in the second loop so the tube could keep moving. “I look good for my age. Also, part of life as a single mom. You get used to acting as the final line of making sure everything gets done, because if you don’t, it won’t. Being in charge is a responsibility.”

“Where is your daughter this weekend, anyway? Could she not come along?” Tori finally finagled the first tube through its final loop and started work on the second. This time, she didn’t need Helen’s help with the pinch trick, utilizing it herself to roughly force the plastic along.

“Too young for this event, and not a Starscout yet. She may not go down that road at all. Penelope is her own creature; she never seems compelled to follow in my footsteps, thank goodness.” Helen looked a tad flustered at that last line, almost like it said more than she intended. “She’s staying with a friend of the family, alongside other kids her age. I daresay

I'll come home to an excited ball of energy, or a completely wiped-out shell of a child."

On the final tube, Tori hit a significant snag, one that no amount of pinching seemed to clear. She started pushing harder, trying to force the plastic through the fabric, only to have Helen's hand fall lightly on her arm. "Stronger isn't always better. Sometimes, you're better off backing up, taking a breath, and trying again."

It was a good thing Ivan had taught Tori to not inadvertently let out heat, because she'd definitely have seared a few holes in the tent's thin material otherwise. Pausing for a few attempts at calming breaths, she wiggled the tube into the loop once more, and this time found it moved without issue. Whatever configuration of fibers had caused the blockage had moved on their own when she yanked out the tube.

"There we go. Very well done. Now, we get the stakes, and I show you how to keep this bad boy bolted to the ground." Helen hopped lightly to her feet; she was a surprisingly spry woman when she wanted to be. As Tori dug through a bag, she looked back to Ivan.

He was still going one box at a time, even as some of the other cluster leaders were hauling visibly heavier loads. But they were the strapping sort, the kind one expected to find unbothered by heft. Ivan was leaner—not that his body would have accurately portrayed his strength if he were three stories tall—and therefore had to pretend to be weaker. It was the commitment to the identity that she admired more than anything. No one would have blinked if Ivan opted to carry two boxes at a time instead of one, yet he refused to make even that small of a compromise. He lived his role unerringly, devoted to the deception. Tori wasn't sure she'd ever be that good, or had the desire to try. The easier path seemed to be avoiding people, especially capes, wherever possible.

"Gotcha!" Helen emerged from her bag with a handful of metal skewers, each tilted at a sharp angle on a single end. "Come grab an end. You can hold the tent in place while I hammer."

At least here, Tori didn't have to pretend. Fire powers and meta-suits didn't help one bit with getting a tent ready. Maybe that was why Ivan liked the office—it asked him to rise to challenges that Fornax never could. Come to think of it, that might be why she'd managed to find a bit of joy there as well. It wasn't the right environment for her long-term, but it had

definitely taught Tori that there were ways to be fulfilled outside of science and stealing.

And at the end of today, she'd have learned an entirely new skill. She might not touch another tent ever again, or she could be hurled into some wasteland tomorrow. It never hurt to have a skill, by her reckoning, so Tori paid close attention as Helen lined up the first metal skewer.

"This is the best part, because unlike with the tubing, here hitting things hard *does* tend to fix all your problems." Helen smashed down on the skewer with the heel of her palm, driving it into the dirt.

"If only life could be so simple," Tori mused.

"I don't know, I think if you hit your problems often enough, you'll probably run out of them," Helen replied. "Either one would hit back harder than you could handle, or you'd drive off all the people and things that caused the problems to start with. Both pretty bad endings, if you ask me."

Tori shrugged. "It helps if you're a misanthrope."

"Funny, you sure do have a lot of people in your life for someone who just claimed to dislike them." Helen smiled, extending the next metal skewer. "Want to take a crack at the next one? Sounds like someone could do to show the ground what-for."

Weird choice of phrasing aside, Tori wasn't going to turn down the opportunity. If she had to learn this, she might as well learn it well. Plus, there was something to be said for the therapy of smacking inanimate objects.

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## Chapter 73

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In his life, Ivan had been no stranger to unique experiences. From fake tournaments in space, to several mystical Christmas adventures, to traveling through a land made from mirrors and terror, to being summoned as a hero in a world of magic; yet he still counted this as one of the most surreal moments he'd ever experienced. Standing in the middle of a gigantic facility, surrounded by kids and other cluster leaders, amidst one of the biggest events of the Starscouts year. That he was here at all was bizarre, that Beth was along as well pushed it into the realm of unbelievable, and then, when one factored in Helen... were Ivan more confident about his prospects in whatever afterlife awaited, he might have thought himself unknowingly dead and ascended.

Of course, this was no heaven, which was why he had to snag the tumbling child who nearly came down headfirst on a punchbowl in their excitement for snacks. He was at this social on-the-clock, as an official of the organization, with a duty to uphold—though that duty was coming in fits and spurts, as the children were largely occupied.

All manner of food, drink, and snack had been brought in for the post-dinner social. The hall was largely segmented off into a more active section, versus one for restful engagement. There were games on both sides, things like cards and Velcro darts with minimal potential for causing damage. Some kids were playing, others chatting, and a brave few were already out on the dance floor, going to town. Beth was among a group of friends from prior years, catching up as they tossed bean bags at a slanted plank of wood, and he noticed Tori making rounds near one of the snack tables. She was

grazing freely, but also helping out the kids who'd piled their plates too high, so she was at least earning her nibbles.

The whole ordeal was so peaceful and fun, it set his teeth on edge. Youth did not come with pleasant associations for Ivan. It was hard not to expect one of these children to wheel around and strike while another's guard was down. He envied this life of theirs, but couldn't be jealous. Ivan didn't even have the capacity to imagine experiencing a normal childhood—the scars of reality ran much too deep. It didn't matter, anyway. There was no changing the past. Watching his daughter smile and laugh without so much as a smidge of fear, Ivan told himself that was all the normal he needed.

"Hmmm, I'm a little worried about that dance floor. Should somebody get it started?"

In another life, Ivan would have grinned at the sound of Helen's voice arriving at his side. Instead, he merely nodded, letting perhaps a small spark of good humor into his eyes. "There are already kids dancing."

"Like six, and two of them are doing something interpretive. Sure seems like somebody should get it started." Helen bumped against Ivan's arm with her shoulder. "How's the trip treating you so far?"

"No issues to report."

The sigh that came from her lips was almost painfully familiar. "Not what I asked. I wanted to know how it's going. Are you enjoying yourself? Because it's okay if you are. You do get to be happy sometimes, Ivan."

It was the sort of thing only she could say with sincerity, the reason Helen was more dangerous than any other cape. She believed in people, to the core, and while that had made her job all the harder at times, it also meant she'd managed things like influencing Fornax, something that even Ivan would have considered impossible at the time.

"I am happy every day. I am grateful every day. I know where my path was supposed to lead, and each morning I rise fully aware that I'm living on bonus time."

"It isn't bonus time. It's your life." Helen paused as a trio of kids bolted past, eyes on the diminishing mound of homemade cookies, many of which bore Ivan's favored recipe. She touched Ivan's shoulder, drawing his attention over to Tori, who'd accepted a dart challenge from one of the scout teams and was proceeding to miss wildly. One even managed to land

on a particularly fuzzy jacket of a nearby reveler, the Velcro hooking in on impact. “At least Tori’s taking to the vibe well.”

Looking at her, Ivan imagined the hard-faced young woman he’d first met in that cell. She never would have been able to blend in like this, her entire focus had been on the next move in front of her face. Now, she was not only thriving as a civilian, she was building up an entire new identity with history and contacts. One day, he truly hoped Tori would see a way out of this life for herself. Sadly, that was a journey she’d have to take on her own. Ivan couldn’t light a path he’d never traveled.

“She’s the adaptable sort. High intelligence doesn’t hurt, either.”

Another round of kids passing caused a pause, only this time, the conversation didn’t start right up again when they cleared. Instead, Helen lingered at his side. “You know, given the context of the situation, I’m sure no one would bat an eye at two cluster leaders hitting the dance floor together in a fun, friendly dance. How about like when you-know-who dealt with the... okay, I actually don’t remember the name of this one. Red thing, lots of ooze and tentacles, plus it ate small chunks of time?”

“KronDabbler,” Ivan supplied.

The triumphant slap on her knee was so loud it drew looks from some of the nearby scouts, forcing Helen to wave at them awkwardly.

“KronDabbler! Right. Like with KronDabbler—you go right, I go left, except, when we meet in the middle, we flip punches for box steps.”

“I know how to dance, enough to realize you might be a few decades out of sync with that box step idea.”

“Nah, everything is cyclical. It’s either back already, or we’ll get it there. Also, way to go blowing the whole ‘brooding silent guy’ thing by admitting you’ve danced. Keep the glower going. The rest of us are using your presence to lightly scare any of the rowdier kids.”

The truth was, Ivan had been to many bars and clubs in his villain days where idly moving in some semblance of time with the beat was enough to qualify as dancing, but it had been his wedding that had forced him to learn some actual steps. As small and simple as the ceremony was, they still went through the major hallmarks: first dance, bouquet, cake-cutting, all to fill the scrapbook with photographic evidence of normalcy. Yet for some reason... no... for a reason Ivan recognized instantly but chose not to acknowledge, he didn’t want to mention that fact to Helen.

“I can put on my annoyed face if anyone gets truly troublesome. Were I to go as far as vexed, I might end up giving them nightmares, however.”

To his surprise, that didn't garner any sort of laugh or chuckle. Looking down, he noticed Helen's gaze wasn't on the scene around them currently; it was aimed off somewhere in her brain that only she could see. He didn't have to wonder what was on her mind for long. Helen was never one to draw things out.

“Seeing all these kids... do you ever imagine what your life would have been like if you'd gotten a more normal childhood? What sort of person you'd have grown into with a different start?”

“No.” With almost anyone else, he'd have left it there. “I don't dream about the impossible. If I'd ended up somewhere else, then whoever came out of that wouldn't be me. He'd probably be better in a lot of ways, but even as a concept, that other me is so far removed from who I actually am that he's a stranger.”

“I wonder about that. I think some of this Ivan might be deeper rooted than you realize.”

Not wanting to let things settle there, Ivan turned the question around. “How about you?”

Helen shook her head. “We're in different boats. I made it to nineteen living normally. I had time to develop and engage with mundane life. Remove that one night where it all changed, and a whole lot about my life would be different, but I think I'd still be more or less the same person. Probably less confident.”

“Oh my, a Helen with more modesty? Perish the very concept.” In spite of the heady topic, Ivan laughed. Something about being around her just made it hard for his mood not to stay light. “Aside from the obvious two child-shaped reasons I would never change my past, you realize that version of Ivan wouldn't have met you, right?”

“Huh. You know, I genuinely hadn't considered it. You've been around so long, I guess I just automatically picture you in my life.”

The long stretch that went between them then had nothing to do with more kids, and far more to do with the unspoken line that Helen had just come dangerously close to slipping over. Both found something to occupy their attention elsewhere, avoiding eye contact.

When the song changed and two of the dancing kids exited the floor, Helen saw her opportunity for as graceful an exit as she could hope to

manage. “Okay, now we’re down to four. It is definitely time someone got it started.”

Unsure whether to roll his eyes or smirk, Ivan did neither, opting instead to play along. “But where will we find a cluster leader with the self-confidence to—”

“Of course I will!” Helen charged onto the dance floor, clearly not having actually listened to Ivan’s reply, busting out such classics as the Lawnmower and Driving the Bus before the song’s first chorus had even been reached. It was a performance of pure cringe, made all the stranger for Ivan since he had firsthand knowledge that not only was Helen incredibly graceful, she’d taken multiple types of professional dance instruction. None of which could be seen in the display of her grabbing one knee and bouncing with it as she spun slowly around on one leg.

Across the room, interest turned to laughter, as one would expect in such an equation. Except afterwards, the process wasn’t over. By whatever strange alchemy of charisma Helen possessed, the amusement turned into fun. From the fringes, more kids wandered onto the dance floor, confident that nothing they did could possibly be as ridiculous as the moves Helen was busting out. She’d turned herself into the attention target, letting everyone else feel freer for the distraction. He even caught sight of Beth’s group migrating toward the music.

Tori wandered over, having soundly lost her game of darts, and examined Helen’s performance with an uncertain eye. “Well that’s... something. Don’t take this wrong, I like Helen, she’s nice and all, but the lady kind of does her own thing, doesn’t she?”

In a weekend filled with double-speak and subterfuge, it was a pleasant break to be able to answer with complete honesty. “Helen has the surety of someone who knows exactly who they are, and is comfortable with it. Obviously, she’s a total weirdo. That’s what happens when you lose all fear of what other people think.”

Taking one brief moment to stretch, Ivan started off toward the dance floor, resolved to hanging back at the edges. She was meant for the spotlight, he for the shadows; they both knew where they worked best.

“Um, what are you doing?” Tori asked, unable to believe what the context clues were suggesting.

Ivan didn’t stop, but he did turn back to answer, an equal mix of amusement and exasperation in his tone. “Probably a box step, sooner or



later. She has a habit of getting her way.”



Lozora hadn't expected approaching the Starscout site to be easy—Lodestar would never let this many vulnerable kids be gathered in one place under her name without protections in place. It was that openness to being challenged that led her to accept her employer's tech. It galled her, needing something as external as his tools, but the call had proven to be prudent.

The external energy barrier would have sliced her clean in half without the disruptor blade, and the mechanical sentries she'd battled would have radioed in about an intruder if not for her signal jammer. Supposedly, even the dark material clinging roughly to her skin was helping, warping the view of any electronic surveillance device that happened to pick her up.

Her handiest tool was unquestionably the mapping device, however. What had started life as a simple Indigo Technologies tablet, the itPad as they were commonly known, had little save for the screen still in common with its original configuration. Lozora's employer had incorporated scanning utilities, along with some hacked satellite feeds, to build a mobile map-generation utility. Just by walking around, the area was revealing itself to her.

Tonight was all about reconnaissance. Targeting Fornax meant getting him nearly alone, down to just his cluster. They wanted pure data on how long he'd be held; the more unplanned factors introduced, the greater the chance they got faulty information. Tomorrow, when the games started, there would be chances. So long as Lozora knew the terrain, she had a fair shot at maneuvering around without being caught. Once the orb was thrown, that would steal everyone's attention while she holed up out of sight.

Stalking through the woods was hardly her idea of a fun weekend, but Lozora bore the task without complaint. Roughly a week to go until the real fun started, and all her work would pay off. One step at a time, though.

First, she had a legendary super-villain to piss off.

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## Chapter 74

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The End of Summer Shindig schedule was clearly not here to fuck around. Before even sunrise, Tori was up with her cluster, dealing with poor sleep thanks to a combination of laying on the dirt and excessive sugar after all her snacking. There was no respite to be had upon waking, as it turned out children needed managing in the morning. Armand and Caden had to be shooed away from messing with their sleeping bags, both certain that two bags could be combined into an uber slumber cocoon, while Mallory sat to the side, explaining the flaws in their logic. For a moment, they thought Newton had vanished, but he turned out to merely be running around the campground, burning off some extra energy. Loyce and Trudy were trying to grill pine cones on the embers of a low fire, but at least they'd gotten ready first. Most of guiding the kids was on Helen and Ivan, who managed it well; however, with this many to track, they definitely needed the extra help.

Once the kids were on the right track, Tori managed to stumble through a shower at one of the facilities, getting in before the lines turned unmanageable, then forcing herself to throw down some food in the mess. On her own, she might have skipped the firm flapjacks and runny eggs, but this was not a day to be running on half a tank. By the time she'd finished slamming her breakfast, it was time to hustle to the lake for her cluster's first event.

Due to the number of scouts present, there was no way for the entire gathering to do the same activities concurrently. Instead, a rotating schedule had been established weeks prior, noting where each cluster would go

through the day. They might tackle a task in the morning that others wouldn't face until that evening, yet by the end of the celebration, every group would have scores to be tallied. While not all of the events were competitive in nature, they were common enough that no one would forget they were playing for stakes. Mostly small trophies and bragging rights, but stakes all the same.

First Aid Relay was her cluster's starting activity, a test of their education in semi-realistic environments. Each cluster would see a "victim" fall over at the opposite end of the lake's beach. It would be on them to check the dummy's vitals, perform CPR, and find a way to move it safely back across the rough terrain of sand. A Starscout leader was on hand to make sure they handled every step properly, taking notes on the details that would ultimately become their score.

She watched at Ivan's side as the kids tore down the beach, kicking up plumes of sand that spun along on the wind, then drifted out over the water before finally settling back down. Newton got there first, with Beth close on his heels. To Tori's surprise, Ivan's daughter took the lead on checking vitals and executing CPR. Beth hadn't ever mentioned either subject, yet she looked like an aspiring EMT as she assessed the dummy's condition.

It was only afterward, when she had a moment to ask Ivan, that Tori got greater understanding. Part of Beth's ability-control training incorporated enhanced emergency education; the idea being that, if they knew what to do in an emergency, there would be less chance of panic and unintended flare-ups. In the moment, though, all Tori knew was that Beth had flown through the medical stuff, finishing just as Caden finally plodded his way up to join the rest of the cluster.

With Mallory calling out positions, the cluster dispersed the dummy's weight amongst themselves, while Armand and Trudy were dedicated to keeping the neck steady in case of injury during the fall. A touch excessive, given the short drop and soft landing material, but more concern typically fared better than less when it came to the practice of medicine. They kept a steady pace, moving with swiftness and surety, balancing the need for speed against the precarious balance of walking along sand. The fact that they stayed together so well spoke to excellent coordination and teamwork, far better than loads of adult teams Tori had seen throughout her life.

Of the three clusters, theirs was easily the first to return, stoking an unexpected spark of pride in Tori. That didn't necessarily mean they'd done

the best—speed was only a single piece of the overall assessment—but it damn sure wouldn't hurt. Cheers and high-fives were passed around freely in celebration. Then, once the jubilation had faded, minds turned to the next task on their docket. The kids were old pros at this, changing from one challenge to the next without so much as a missed step. The exuberance and adaptability of youth were marvelous qualities; Tori wondered if any meta had found a way to bottle that. Then she realized the sorts of steps and ingredients that would probably go into such a concoction and figured if that meta had existed, the guild would have sent Kristoph calling almost immediately.

Being less flexible, Tori had to mentally shift gears as they wandered away from the lake, heading out to a wooded area. No more running on sand. Next up, they had to make and break down a campfire safely, a notion that still tickled Tori even days after learning about it. Then, there was the first crafting challenge, a relay race, and then finally, after the nature hike, they'd get to break for lunch.

Thinking about the long day ahead, Tori almost wished she'd forced down a few more of those stiff pancakes. Almost, but not quite.



“When you said you wanted to up your training after that last fight, I was on board. When you asked me to find a remote location with lots of high, sheer surfaces, I obliged. Even once you told us you'd be bringing along weights from the gym, we rolled with it. But at this point, I think we're going to need an explanation.”

Cyber Geek nodded to the pile of chains resting in the dirt next to the weights, all of it sitting in the shadow of the rocky outgrowth looming over them. Cold Shoulder seemed less concerned, whereas Hat Trick wore a comically puzzled face, a slight sliver of tongue poking out the side of her mouth, seemingly unnoticed.

“I've been doing a lot of weights and sparring, but Hephaestus didn't just get stronger since the last time—he got smoother. The guy was crazy light on his feet for how heavy that suit was. I thought long and hard about what exercise would help me the most.” As he spoke, Medley began to loop the first chain around his torso.

“The act of free-climbing will strengthen my hands and feet while I use my claws to dig into the rock. Hauling the extra weight makes it harder, meaning I’ll also get stronger. But I don’t just want to be heavy, I want to be unwieldy. Hence the chain.”

Medley picked up a weight and tied off a section of chain; however, it wasn’t bound close to his body. Instead, it landed several feet away. Given the slack, it would dangle from Medley once he started ascending, yanking him to and fro. “Different weights at different lengths is going to make it incredibly hard to move with any sense of fluidity. I’ve never really trained full-body dexterity before, but I figure pushing myself is a good place to start.”

“You’re sure this is safe, right?” Hat Trick asked.

“Definitely not. That’s why I asked you all to come along. Hardy as I am, that summit is a good ways up. Good to have friends around, just in case.”

“There are other ways to get stronger, you know.” Cyber Geek expected the words to fall on deaf ears, yet he had to speak them, all the same. They had decided to stick him in the leadership role, and saying what everyone already knew was part of the gig.

Medley kept on working with his chain, tying off the second weight. “Maybe for you. You’re still growing like you were at the start. Some of us are starting to plateau. We’re getting passed, by villains and fellow superheroes alike. If I want to keep up, it means taking things to the next level, so I hope you’ve got a healing item on hand.”

“Still no luck with consumables,” Cyber Geek reported. He’d tried summoning a variety of potions and power-ups, all of which came over fine, but turned back to sparks and numbers when he tried to ingest them. “The hunt continues, though I could summon a set of attack-ribbons that wind tight on impact to contain bleeding. Between that and your speed-healing, we should have time to get you help.”

“Let’s hope it doesn’t come to that.” Cold Shoulder was already beginning to form her ice-construct—a huge body that might be able to catch Medley, depending on where he hypothetically tumbled from.

Adding the last two weights, Medley moved across the ground, feeling them drag like the anchors they were. He ran his claws along the rough stone surface, locating purchase, and then hauled his body up from the dirt. That was the easy part; Medley could more than handle his own heft. When

the first hundred-pound weight came off the ground, it was an inconvenience. By the fourth, Medley could feel the strain running along his arms and legs. It was a good pain, the ache of strength to come, the price of getting stronger.

Another handhold as the climb began in earnest. The weights clanked as Medley rose, his friends watching carefully from the ground below. So far to go, and he'd only just begun.



The relay race was, in theory, a simple event. Each scout would run their section of the track to a station, where a Starscout leader would be waiting to ask them a question pertaining to the history or systems of the organization as a whole. If they missed it, they'd be asked another, and so on until they got one right. After that, the baton changed hands and the race continued; a mix of mental and physical challenges rolled into one. What caused them a momentary delay was the fact that one of the cluster's leaders was also expected to participate, starting off for their teams to show the kids how it was done.

On the outside, it was a simple matter of determining who should take the role between Ivan and Helen. Spry as she was, there was no way Helen could hope to compete with Ivan's speed... if Ivan had been willing to show it off. Tori quickly realized the complication: Ivan couldn't tell them that he was stronger and faster than any human here could ever hope to match. Even without actively using his abilities, there was no getting around Ivan's overall power.

Helen, however, had thoughts of her own. "Come on. You're a quick study, but we both know I've got the better knowledge base here. Plus, I mean, you do work a desk job. Can't imagine there's that much opportunity for exercise."

"You'd be surprised by how fast I can learn when motivated, and it's not like this is my first year with the Starscouts. Beth has been a member for much of her life. I've paid attention to the various cardboard presentations throughout the years."

Tori trailed behind them as they led the cluster across the camp to the relay race site. None of the children were paying the adults much attention,

far too enthralled in the joys of the day. Loyce had acquired a large bag of trail mix at some point; she and Caden seemed intent on polishing it off before the next event started. Newton was doing stretches while walking, visibly excited to put his athletic talents on display. Beth, Mallory, and Armand were deep in discussion about what the best order would be, going back and forth even as the final moments drew near.

As for Tori, she found the disagreement between cluster leaders interesting enough on its own, though the others couldn't appreciate the strangeness of what they were beholding. It wasn't seeing people playfully bicker that struck her as odd, it was the fact that Ivan was engaging in such a practice at all. Had she ever seen him argue in jest? Generally, Ivan was either giving or taking orders. There was nothing wrong with it, no reason why he couldn't, it's just that... something about this was odd. A curious itch in her brain she couldn't quite manage to scratch.

"Fine. We'll flip for it." Helen jammed a hand into her right front pocket, drawing the distinct jingle of change until she produced a shiny quarter. "Lucky for you, I've got a soft spot for vending machine snacks."

"Why don't we have Tori flip it, seeing as she's impartial?" Ivan suggested.

That earned them both a scrutinizing glance from Helen. "I'm not so sure about that."

"I am." Tori reached out and grabbed the coin. "I can say with absolute honesty that I don't care which of you does this part, so long as it's not me. Call it in air?"

"Yeah, yeah. I'll even play fair." Helen put a hand over her glasses and eyes, covering her face. "Go ahead."

One more eccentricity from a woman rapidly piling them up. Tori ignored it for now, losing any curiosity to that damned mental itch. She flipped the coin into the air, and at its zenith, Helen called out, eyes still covered. "Heads."

Tori snagged the coin, slapping it down onto the back of her left hand and covering it with her right. Despite the initial apathy, the kids had drawn closer, as well. With the entire cluster looking on, Tori moved her hand, revealing the shiny surface that lay beneath.

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## Chapter 75

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Deep down, Ivan knew he should have let Helen make the run. She knew the organization's history better, and had more protection than he did in case of accidental power displays. That was without even factoring in the mockery that would come if words or photos of this incident ever got out. Had this event come some weeks prior, he'd never have even floated the possibility of being in the relay.

That was before things changed with Rick. Before Ivan had had to start asking himself how long he had with his children still seeing him as their father, instead of as a killer. Rick was already heading down that path; Ivan could only guess the number of years before Beth caught on as well. He wanted to build new memories while it was still an option, some pleasant recollections for them to hang on to once the hideous truth finally came to light. And, perhaps, these memories were for him, as well. Pieces of the life he knew could fall out from under his feet on any given step.

A sparse woods dotted the nearby landscape, leading to a sharp, rocky incline that turned into a lumpy hill. The stretch of track ran in a loop measuring roughly a mile, bordering up to the edge of the incline before circling back to the starting point where Ivan currently waited. With him were most of the cluster, along with Trey and Yuri, the leaders of the cluster they'd be racing against. Yuri would be his competition. While Trey looked like he could handle hauling firewood, she unquestionably was the faster mover. Her partner hung back with the scouts who wouldn't be participating.



At the other end of the track, Tori and Helen were positioned. Since the kids were spaced out along the route, they'd done the same with the adults, ensuring that if anything went wrong, the kids could be reached quickly. Five stations lined the equidistant points, all with a radio and a scout from each cluster waiting. That was where they'd be given their questions, though rather than have five staff members standing around, one referee could deliver all queries from a single device. That was also why a cluster leader was posted on the opposite side of the track—a little observation helped ensure that everyone played fair.

"Good luck!" Yuri called to Ivan from her starting position a few feet over, seemingly with genuine sincerity.

He put on his most pleasant face and waved. "To you, as well!" It didn't hurt to set good sportsmanship examples with the kids watching.

For the barest of moments, Ivan's past tried to break through, reminding him of the sorts of tasks he'd endured at that age. With absolute will, he denied it, sending the memory back into the pits from which it came. As Ivan, that part of him had to be sealed away, locked completely down. Those sorts of recollections served Fornax when the need arose; Ivan had no purpose for them. At most, they were reminders of what he was working so hard to ensure: that no child, especially not his, ever suffered through that again.

A crackle of static came over the walkie-talkie on Trey's belt. "We're ready to go with the questions when you are."

"Okay, folks, that means we're about ready to race." Trey's husky voice went well with his dense body, easily commanding the attention of the kids milling about. "Leaders, are you both ready?"

Ivan threw a thumbs-up, which Yuri mimicked moments later. Trey evidently caught the gestures, taking one last look over the track before he gave the order. "Perfect. Then take your positions, because the relay race begins in three... two... one... go!"

Obviously, Ivan wasn't running at full speed. Even without actively using the tremendous amount of power that coursed through him, or a hint of magic, at his baseline he was still well past human limitations. Unless Yuri was hiding super-speed, he'd win, and even that trick would only work until he equalized the temporal distortion. Fornax couldn't reach the tiers of true speed on his own, but he did have the ability to match an opponent, not that it was a skill he needed while plodding along a fifth of a mile. In the

end, he more or less matched Yuri's pace. Sometimes he got a little ahead, sometimes a bit behind, until the last stretch, where he surged slightly ahead and stayed there. Fair play was all well and good, but he *did* like to win.

"Ivan Gerhardt of cluster number two-three-seven, checking in."

Although he tried to put a weary gasp in there midway through, it was clear to any observer that the effort hadn't significantly winded him.

The radio crackled as Caden and the other cluster's kids looked on, waiting for their moment to shine. After a half-second of static, the question arrived.

"What year was the first End of Summer Shindig held?"

In his mind, he could hear Helen's voice, rattling off Starscout history during their meetings. That one, he didn't need her help with, however. Despite the last memory's failure, a new one bubbled up. Lodestar's face, on the boxy old televisions inside the store display. Her smiling, cheery expression as she flew past a sun rising over an idyllic lake. Ivan could still picture it perfectly, still remember his absolute confoundment at the image. By then, she and Fornax had briefly traded blows, though he didn't yet have any idea what he was truly up against. At the time, he'd only been perplexed at the idea that someone strong enough to stand up to him would use their time on such stupid, pointless projects.

Funny, the way life loved to wrap around and remind Ivan of his own past idiocy. At least this time, it was useful for something. "The year was nineteen-ninety-three. Three years after the Starscouts were officially founded." One year after a young man dripping in blood crawled his way out of a hidden hellhole, blinded and terrified by his first time seeing the sun.

"Correct. You may hand off!"

Just as Caden had a firm grip on the baton, Yuri caught up. She wasn't far behind at all; Ivan had given his cluster a small advantage, not a guaranteed victory. Across the track, near Helen and Tori, he could see Beth waiting. She was the mid-runner, taking the third leg of the race. She put up a double thumbs-up, clearly celebrating their early success, before turning her eyes toward the approaching form of Caden.

By the time Ivan's attention was back around him once more, Yuri's question was done and her kid was off, slowly gaining on Caden's narrow lead. He was far from the most athletic member of the cluster, but they had some strong runners still left, with Newton acting as their anchor. Ivan

moved back toward the other kids, cheering loudly as he did. It didn't really matter who won or lost; the experience was the important thing. But he could still root for victory, especially with his daughter among the competitors.

He was so lost in the moment, Ivan didn't even catch the minor spike of magical energy that came from the other side of the hill.



At the prick of her finger, the orb came alive. One drop of blood, not even human blood at that, was all it took to start the various mechanisms running. Initially, Lozora had considered waiting until the group was entirely on their own, hitting them on the nature hike. After a night hunkering low, Lozora had decided that expediency took priority. She rationalized it by thinking that the longer she stayed, the greater her chances of discovery. Besides, this would catch Fornax even more off guard. As for the extra civilians, they shouldn't impact the data. Ten kids or twenty, dead weight was dead weight. Fornax would have to deal with that either way.

Based on reputation, Lozora might have expected Fornax to simply wipe everyone else out on the off chance it would make escape easier on himself, but after seeing him run a fifth of a mile in a Starscout leader uniform, she was having her doubts. While Fornax might be physically down there, it appeared as if the legendary villain might well have already been dealt with. This hardly seemed like the kind of man who could disrupt her employer's plans. But that was why they tested: to be sure, rather than work off supposition alone.

Several clicks came from within the orb, and Lozora counted them. The timing was key. If she got it wrong, Lozora herself would wind up in the trap. It was a situation she'd eventually be able to escape from, but not without losing a significant amount of time. Anything strong enough to hold Fornax would be a murderous gauntlet for most meta-humans—even Lozora would have to work carefully to escape.

With a *kerchunk*, the first panel of the orb slid away, revealing a stretch of bright green beneath. It rattled, expanding in size, and Lozora reared back. Almost time now. She waited, tense, until a sharp hiss rose from the device. That was her final cue, and with precise aim, Lozora chunked the

orb through the air, over the hill she was hiding behind, toward Fornax's position. The moment it left her hand, Lozora began to race in the opposite direction, all concern for stealth temporarily cast aside.

In order to make sure Fornax was caught, Cobblord had built a big range onto this trap. Brave as Lozora was in the face of danger, not even she wanted to be stuck inside the same cage where she'd just thrown Fornax. By the time she made it to a crop of trees to hang on to, the smaller rocks from the hill were already rising into the air.



For a moment, it was perfect. Beth won her part of the relay; Loyce lost them a few steps, but made up for it in trivia, getting Newton a clean handoff. He was trucking down the track, closing the small gap his opponent had built up. The others were nearly back—even Helen and Tori had started trekking over. It was a nice, normal, happy moment. Then Ivan felt the surge of energy. He might have stood out, craning his neck skyward, except that was about the time things started to fly.

Well, rise, really. Water bottles, kicked-off shoes, even hats clean off of scouts' heads. It all started to lift up, rising toward the rapidly expanding sphere overhead. The bigger it grew, the more details Ivan could make out. It was grassy inside, with long streaks of gray, like stone, and he was almost certain he caught movement in a few areas. Instantly, Ivan recognized the quality of the work. It was too specialized; only Cobblord could craft a custom portable world. Unfortunately, that also meant it wouldn't be easy to avoid without overtly using his powers. Cobblord's traps always sprang well.

A moment later, Ivan realized escape was never an option. The kids were rising too, a few fully leaving the ground. His eyes locked on Beth, who had been slowly jogging back to the group, and now upgraded to a full-on sprint. It probably would have been more effective had she not just been forced to race; Ivan could see her steps landing lighter as she drew steadily higher.

"What the hell is that thing?" Behind Ivan, Trey was panicking—a very reasonable reaction to the sight he was beholding. Any answer that could be offered would only raise more questions, so Ivan ignored it, focusing on

controlling the situation while they still had a chance. With one look, it was clear he wouldn't be able to save all of the kids from going in—there just too many, and some of them were already halfway into the air. If keeping them out of it wasn't an option, then Ivan's only choice was to protect them on the inside.

"Keep the kids together," Ivan ordered, more force in his voice than he'd have used with the children. "Seems like we're going in no matter what. We can't risk them ending up alone."

The draw was starting to effect Ivan, as well. He weighed considerably more than the scouts yet could still feel the pull. Trey was already getting light on his feet, so Ivan made use of the movement he still had. Racing ahead with more speed than he'd been willing to show on the track, Ivan barreled across the field, to where the kids who'd been running were making their way back. He grabbed the ones he could reach, hurling them back in Trey's direction. They were still floating, but at least now, they'd hopefully come down with the others.

Beth didn't get tossed, however. By the time Ivan got there, she was too high, out of reach. With a single jump, he left the ground, sailing up through the air until he nearly collided into her. She grabbed on as soon as he came near, visibly scared, but still holding her composure.

"What is this thing?"

"A momentary obstacle," Ivan assured her. Looking up, he could see the structure in more detail now. There were stretches of forest, stone ruins, even cliffs and hillsides. Too big; this orb would be easy to lose people in. From his belt, Ivan grabbed a walkie-talkie, hoping that Trey still had his turned on.

"Listen to me, anyone being pulled in. We're going to rendezvous at the huge stone tower near the edge of that forest. Stay low, be quiet, and get there no matter what." From where the bulk of the kids appeared to be heading, that should be a straight shot for them to reach. He, Beth, and anyone else who'd been too far back would have a tougher trip, but they had the benefit of Ivan's willingness to crush any threat that might appear.

Having Beth secured, Ivan looked over to the section of the field he'd worried about the least, the area with Helen. She and Tori were both airborne, neither looking especially thrilled about it, though Helen's face spoke more to confliction than fear. If she transformed, it would be nothing to snatch the kids up out of the air. But in doing so, she'd also give away

that Lodestar had been here, which meant the Starscouts would be potential targets anytime someone wanted to lure her out. Not to mention, if this was only the first step of some unknown plan, revealing their ace in the hole too early might leave them vulnerable down the line. Ivan did the only thing he could think of in the moment to help.

“I’ve got them!” Ivan yelled, hoping his words would reach across the long stretch of open air. “Just worry about keeping her safe.”

Both Tori and Helen nodded at that—a confusing reaction that Ivan didn’t have time to consider, because he was no longer floating. They had officially crossed the halfway point to the massive orb. Ivan could feel space rippling around them, packing the expanse of this microcosm into an sphere much too small to contain it. Passing that point meant they were now falling toward a new surface, rather than rising from the old one. As the ground drew near, Ivan pulled Beth in close, encasing her as best he could from all potential harm.

In the moment, Ivan’s entire focus was on getting her and the rest of the kids out of this safely. When that was done, when his anger could be allowed to stretch, Fornax would have a great deal to say to Cobblord and whoever hired him. That came later, though. For the moment, he had a portable labyrinth to deal with.

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## Chapter 76

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In her youth, Helen would have already changed. Glasses cast aside, blazing through the air, she would have snatched every child out of the trap's pull and spirited them to presumed safety. Experience had taught her many things through the years, and one of them was the importance of patience. If someone had gone to all the trouble of securing a Cobblord creation, sneaking onto Starscout grounds, and deploying it, then she couldn't assume this to be the only trick in their bag. Until she knew what this was about, who she was against, and what powers were in play, it was preferable to save her big surprise. Rescue everyone now, and the perpetrators would clock Lodestar's presence, almost certainly triggering them to flee and try again later down the line. She might be able to catch them, but this was too much preparation to assume there wasn't some manner of escape plan.

All of which flashed through Helen's mind before she remembered that transforming could potentially out her secret to Tori, as well as to any of the kids or staff who happened to be looking over. That was a factor to be concerned with, but a secondary one. Protecting the kids came first.

Her eyes scanned the approaching orb, which appeared to be increasing in size as they drew closer. She spotted several moving creatures made entirely of stone, as well as some smaller ones that appeared to be constructed from grass and twigs. Cobblord was an efficient designer; he'd used the terrain of the labyrinth to stock it with pseudo-life. No need to feed them, and more could probably be formed if their numbers were cut down.

Certainly, they were dangers in other circumstances; however, for her or Ivan, there was nothing to present a significant challenge.

It was as she was visually combing their destination that she locked eyes with Ivan, who was already clutching Beth and pulling all the kids near him close. They'd be bunched up when they landed, and from the looks of things, not too far from the rest of the cluster. She and Tori, on the other hand, were drifting toward a canyon; based on their trajectory, Helen estimated they'd come down about a mile over from it. On her own, a minor matter to cross. With Tori in tow, it meant they had to either go around or fly, the latter of which came with a lot of required explanation.

"I've got them!" Ivan's voice would not be confined by such mortal hurdles as wind or distance. "Just worry about keeping her safe."

What a silly thing, the assurance she felt at those simple words. No one could "have them" in this sort of situation. It was dangerous, the kids were in peril, and they had essentially zero clue as to what they were up against. Yet all the same, Helen knew they'd be safe. Villain or civilian, when Ivan said he'd do something: he'd knock the gates of hell from their hinges to keep his word. With his daughter there, looking to him for protection, she truly couldn't imagine the threat that would successfully stop Ivan.

If he was taking over guarding their charges, then that meant it was on her to find the maze's center. Every Cobblord labyrinth could be safely destroyed and exited from their middles; he was as faithful to his theming as he was to his prices, both famously inflexible. Tearing it apart by hand was technically an option, but he tended to build in disastrous, often explosive, consequences for those who tried to cheat. On her own, she'd have blasted right through this sphere, and then wiped off all the sings. With a mass of Star Scouts in the mix, the safest option was to do this properly.

Their descent speed was increasing, and Helen noticed Tori bracing for impact. Poor thing was probably tearing herself up wondering whether or not to turn into fire upon landing, debating if broken limbs were worth a lost secret.

"Don't worry!" Helen said, raising her voice to be heard over the whistling of the air in their ears. "We slow down before landing."

The sharp, focused look Tori shot her was a curious reaction, but she did seem to be less immediately terrified. As for Helen, she spent the rest of their descent making as precise a mental map as possible. For most of the



people being drawn in, this was all chaos, but she was used to looking at things from above. While the route she spotted was rough in patches, it definitely seemed to lead somewhere. That was as good a start as any.

Lifting her hands up like she was on a roller-coaster, Helen let out a sharp squeal of fun as the drop-speed grew, plummeting them toward the orb's ground. Ivan and the kids were out of sight—the warping space pushed them further away with every passing second. Since he had their walkie-talkie, Helen could only hope that Ivan would either be able to handle any danger, or be wise enough to yell for help. The faster she and Tori could end this, the less time those kids would be in even the slightest danger.

Behind her, the real world fell away as the artificial sky locked into place. They were officially contained in the trap. From this point on, the only way out was victory, or destroying the labyrinth entirely. The ground was rising up toward them at an incredible rate, and Helen permitted herself to savor the sensation of falling.

It was actually kind of fun, when one wasn't concerned about the landing.



Between the surprise, terror, and sudden rush of ground, Beth had apparently blacked out. She stirred slowly, feeling the strange grass against her skin. It was the right color, shape, even smell, yet something was inherently off. No one factor she could put her finger on, yet she instantly recognized the facsimile of foliage for what it was. Lifting her head, Beth spotted several other Starscouts, most of whom were either unconscious or barely starting to wake.

With a flash of terror, she realized her dad wasn't there. What happened? He'd been holding her as they fell, so he couldn't have landed elsewhere. Did that mean something had gotten to him? Beth knocked that idea aside; she knew the wilderness too well. No wild animal would go for one target in a sea of unconscious bodies.

Just as she was about to call out, movement from a nearby tree caught Beth's attention.

The leaves rustled as Ivan dropped down from among them, knocking some stray fake-twigs away from his khaki ensemble. At the sight of Beth awake, he hurried over, dropping down to a knee. “How are you feeling? Does anything hurt?”

She shook her head. Now that the pounding fear in her chest was fading, Beth realized she didn’t have so much as a bruise from the impact. Her meta-human ability had proven to make her slightly tougher, but considering that no one else was bleeding or howling in pain, she didn’t appear to be the only one. “I guess the ground is soft?”

“We slowed down just before we hit. The rapid momentum shift must have given you kids all a massive headrush.” Ivan pointed over to the tree he’d just come down from. “The good news is we’re close to most of the others. I spotted Trey, Yuri, and the rest of the scouts; they’re less than a mile from that stone tower. We’ve got a bit more of a trip, but the path isn’t especially difficult. Think of it like a nature hike in very unfamiliar terrain.”

“With alien animals,” Beth added. “I saw stuff moving down here when we were approaching.”

The fake grass squeaked slightly as Ivan slid onto his rear, sitting down next to his daughter. “Not alien. Custom made.” He motioned to the ground, trees, sky, all of it. “This is a trap made by a man called Cobblord. I saw one of those online mini docu-videos about him. Apparently, he specializes in custom creations, and these are his favorite. Used to be, you’d hear news about one appearing yearly. While well-engineered, Cobblord also has certain standards he upholds, one of which is that a labyrinth gets more dangerous the deeper in you go. Out here, in the starting areas, anything you see is likely more scared of you than you are of it.”

“Are you sure it’s safe?”

“Positive,” Ivan said, because he was. Beth didn’t know about his magic, and she certainly didn’t realize he had a low-capacity sleep spell. Even if she had, it was unlikely she’d have realized that two minutes and twenty pass the same while unconscious, especially with no electronics and an artificial sky. Most of all, she definitely wouldn’t have reason to guess that Ivan had spent that time racing around their entire area, destroying everything non-human that so much as twitched.

Not far from where they were, one could reach the lip of a large canyon. Were one to look into it, they might take note of the piled-up stone bodies, dozens of creatures smashed to oblivion and hurled roughly out of the way.

Ivan knew they would all be safe, because he'd ensured there was nothing around to attack. Eventually, the labyrinth would rebuild, but once they had the kids in one place, it would be much easier to protect them. Clearing everyone's path in secret was step one. Step two was rejoining the scout groups. Step three, find shelter—ideally food, if possible.

Step four was where things got complicated. Ivan could either stay with the kids, or try to hunt for the maze's center. It was tempting: wipe out every threat, then race to catch up with Helen and Tori. But if he were there, Ivan's mind would be back among the scouts, worrying for Beth. A compromised ally was often worse than an enemy—besides which, he'd told Helen he would keep them safe. That promise didn't end until the kids were off this orb and back onto... well, a different orb, when one got right down to it, but it was *their* orb.

Movement signaled that the others were shaking off their slumber. Beth had proven surprisingly resilient, waking several full minutes ahead of them. Ivan wasn't sure if that was due to her meta-abilities, potent willpower, or a developed tolerance. The reason he'd learned that spell in the first place was to help Beth rest when she was teething, so she'd gotten a fair few doses through the years. It was one more variable to account for in a situation already spiraling fast out of control. Hopefully, he wouldn't have to lean on any more magic. The ideal way this played out was that he found the other kids, they all hunkered down, and then Helen got them out. For her part, he had no concerns. Saving the day was what Helen did. Ivan just wished he felt quite so sure about his own tactics.

There was something else he hadn't told Beth, a part of the labyrinth that was not quite so comforting. While the starting area *was* the least dangerous, it steadily grew less so. Since the purpose of these places was to make the subject defeat the maze, staying in one spot was discouraged. The longer they stayed camped around here, the more numerous and powerful the creatures would become. By nightfall, the woods would be repopulated. Come morning, the threats would have grown in size and threat. If Ivan planned to let them survive that long, anyway. Once he got the kids with the other counselors, it would be easier to move freely. However long Helen needed, he would hold the line. Regardless of what he had to do or admit, he would not let harm come to these kids. Especially not with Beth sitting there, watching his every move.

Fornax was a villain, a killer, a monster, and so much worse. That had been the only life he ever knew, the only way of being. It wasn't until Wade that Ivan saw friendship in another person's eyes when they looked at him, something he hadn't experienced since the nameless companion Ivan had been tortured into killing. Then came Helen, someone who looked at him like he could be more than what he was.

But none of them came close to his children. For the very first time, Ivan had understood what it was to be a hero. When things went wrong, when they were afraid, when the world seemed darkest, they looked to him, because they knew he'd be there. That trust in him was among the most precious things Ivan had ever possessed. He already knew it was fading with Rick, and Beth probably wouldn't be far behind. Still, for right now, she was looking at him like he could make this okay, keep them safe. Save the day. There was almost nothing he wouldn't do to prove his daughter right.

"Everyone, please stay close as you wake up. The entrance was rough, but you'll be okay after a few minutes to shake it off. I know you're all scared and confused right now. That's not only okay, it's the expected reaction to something like this. However, we are not merely a gaggle of confused civilians. We are Starscouts, which means if anyone is prepared to get through this, it's all of you." Ivan looked to Beth, the only one fully awake so far. "For example, we need to head toward that stone tower. How do we navigate when we lose sight of it?"

From her pocket, Beth produced a compass, carefully noting the tip of the stone tower they could see poking up among the trees. "It's northwest of our current position. Assuming we always head in that general direction and keep checking in when possible, we should be able to find it without much issue."

Not exactly a tough dilemma, but the goal was to make them feel in control of the situation. Hopelessness and helplessness were wily enemies in situations like these. When people felt desperate, they started to make bad decisions. Keeping the kids calm was part of keeping them safe, a task that would only grow harder the longer this lasted.

"Starscouts, you heard Beth. Let's gather ourselves and start moving northwest. Stay close, and if you hear anything, let me know." Taking a defensive position at the front of the group, Ivan pulled away some almost-bushes and led the children toward what he dearly hoped would be safety.

Sparing a slender amount of his already scant mental energy, Ivan wondered how Tori was coping with all of this. Given that she didn't have children to watch or the responsibility to battle the maze, it was likely a much more relaxing endeavor than what he faced. With Helen there to keep her safe, the only real trouble she could get into would be self-inflicted.

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## Chapter 77

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It was testament to how truly fucked up Tori's life had become that she quickly adjusted to the sudden shift in their situation: from a day out watching kids in harmless competitions to being scooped up by a giant floating sphere. Anyone who'd done deep research into meta-humans was at least passingly familiar with Cobblord's works—many of his creations had been huge public spectacles. Tori didn't have the slightest idea how the mazes functioned, unfortunately; only that they popped up, often swallowing bystanders, and vanished only after the capes ventured inside.

Standing on dirt that wasn't quite the right shade of red, Tori looked out over the vast canyon. Wide and deep, with sheer edges and no paths to be seen. Climbing down and then out wouldn't work, not without taking them days. Floating over in fire form was technically an option, if she was willing to reveal her secret and abandon Helen. That wouldn't have been a prudent move in the first place, and it certainly wasn't viable after Ivan's request.

"Just worry about keeping her safe." That was what he'd yelled across the aerial divide. Seeing as Tori was the one with abilities and guild training, it was obvious he wanted her to protect Helen. A much easier task than Ivan's guarding an entire herd of kids, but still not a simple job. Without using her abilities, Tori was going to be relying heavily on hand-to-hand, and some of the creatures she'd seen on their descent looked a might too large for that to mean success. She'd have to make judicious use of "tactical repositioning," the technical term for running like hell when outgunned.

Footsteps caused Tori to whip around and come face to face with Helen, who'd drifted slightly off near the end of the descent. No injuries that Tori could see. She didn't even look especially put out, face still beaming as Helen looked across the sizable divide. Her whistle started high, then dropped low, stretching for a borderline comical amount of time.

"Unless one or both of us is hiding the power of flight, I don't think we're making it across that." Helen seemed a touch more amused than that line really warranted, a detail Tori brushed directly over. "Not that it matters. Now that we're in, the only way out is through. Have to find the center and beat the final obstacle. That will safely release everyone trapped inside."

"Is there a non-safe release option?" Tori asked. She hadn't counted on the possibility of trapped exits, but there was no reason they couldn't be in use.

"Non-safe release is what happens when metas try to cheat. For example, nothing here would really pose much of a challenge to someone like Professor Quantum, but if he decided to blast right to the labyrinth's center, he would trip the failsafe measures, which everyone else inside would have to deal with. Carrot and stick. We either play the game as it's intended, with a chance at a happy outcome, or we cheat and live with the consequences. All of which is moot, in the first place. Obviously, we don't have the shortcut option."

Tori wasn't entirely sure about that. She could cause some potent destruction when needed, and a lot of the stuff here did look flammable. But Helen was right that they wouldn't be risking such tactics. Even without Ivan's fury if anything happened to Beth, Tori wasn't going to risk those kids. She was a criminal, not a piece of shit, and annoying as they could be, that cluster was still hers. Her fists tightened, anger threatening to rise. They were supposed to having a weekend camping trip, a nice, normal event. Some motherfucker had stolen that. From the kids, from Tori, from Ivan and Beth. Nobody hated getting robbed quite like a thief; Tori would have loved to show whoever did this just what a spectacular fuck up it was. Pity she doubted the chance would come. Ivan simply had more clout and connections. He'd get his vengeance first, and anyone who'd dined at his table knew that neither Ivan nor Fornax left any remains.

"What's the plan? Do we try to get a signal out to the capes?" Tori didn't love the feeling of those words on her tongue, but she couldn't very

well suggest that they go attempt to conquer the labyrinth.

“That would take too long. Even if we could send a distress call, which is not an easy task, the way this place has warped space in on itself also means it packed in layers of time around us. Best guess, if we could get a message out right this moment, help might arrive within a week.” Helen slapped Tori lightly on the back, between the shoulder blades. “Good news. Looks like you and I are taking this bad boy on.”

It felt like her brain was stuttering. The ease and cheer on Helen’s face refused to fade, even while she proposed such an insane notion. Maybe Tori could have handled this alone, using her flames to hit and move, but with a human tagging along, their odds dropped substantially.

“I’m not sure we’re the best ones for the task.”

“Does it matter?” Helen managed to make what could have been a snippy retort sound utterly sincere. “We’re the ones here. The other adults can’t go maze-diving, since they have the kids to protect. Innocent people are in danger, and we have the power to help. What other choice is there?”

She wasn’t wrong about the situation. They were the only two who could move freely. Even if Ivan was capable of slipping over and joining them, he’d never leave Beth and the others helpless. Assuming that Helen had accurately estimated the warping of time around the labyrinth, external aid was unlikely to come anytime soon. Regardless of how she turned the situation around mentally, Tori couldn’t find another angle, not with such limited information to go on. There simply was no other way around it. Getting out meant going through.

“I guess there isn’t one,” Tori conceded. “Our only hope is to try. You seem to know these things pretty well—how do we find the center?”

“All roads lead there, eventually. It’s more a matter of how fast or easy a given path might be. I saw a route on our way in—looks troublesome, so that’s our best lead.”

The sudden break in logic almost made Tori miss a step. “Wouldn’t we avoid the troublesome parts?”

“Not if we care about time. The harder the path, the more direct it is to our goal.”

“Is that a rule of mazes?” Tori asked.

“That’s a rule of life. But yes, also applies to these labyrinths.” Helen looked up to the false sky, perhaps searching for an exit, or trying to create



some sense of time. “We shouldn’t be reckless, but we also can’t afford to take too long.”

“Right. The longer everyone’s in here, the greater the chances one of the kids will get hurt.”

To Tori’s shock, Helen waved the notion off half-handedly, not even looking down. “I’m not worried about keeping them safe. Ivan’s there. My concern is that, depending on size, these devices can sometimes take days to properly complete, and we don’t have any food or water. Unless Cobblord happened to build those into this particular model, we’re on the clock with everyone’s own body. Without supplies, we can’t protect them from hunger.”

Casting her eyes around, Tori zeroed in on the foliage. Trees, grass, shrubs, some of it was bound to be edible. But food was secondary compared to water, and even as she scanned, Tori realized that just like the dirt, all of it looked slightly off. Just wrong enough that she wouldn’t feel confident trying to shovel it down, and certainly wouldn’t risk feeding it to one of the scouts. That hadn’t even occurred to her, yet Helen had clocked it as their primary obstacle.

The mental itch flared up once again, soothed by the thin rationalization that it must come from all her Starscout survival training.

“I knew I should have forced down more of those pancakes,” Tori mumbled.

“Ugh, yeah, the food here is dietarily compliant for pretty much anyone, but the flipside is that some of the stuff they took out is what makes it taste good. I made a breakfast muffin run.”

They’d started walking away from the canyon, ambling toward the forest and the route Helen had seen. Tori almost let the comment slip by unnoticed, before she remembered the prior day’s trek. “Wait, how did you make any kind of run? We’re miles from civilization and all came together on the same bus. You don’t have a car.”

Helen didn’t stop walking entirely, however, she did throw a curious glance over her shoulder, almost like she was reassessing Tori. “You’ve got a knack for critical thinking. Most people wouldn’t have noticed that. Anyway, I probably meant I made a breakfast muffin run before we came and packed a case in one of my bags.”

A rogue pang in Tori’s stomach signaled the first beginnings of hunger, an issue she’d have been far less concerned with one hour prior. “We should

stop talking about food. I don't think it's leading anywhere productive."

Walking along the grass, it was easy to clock the shifts in terrain. After ten minutes, all signs of dirt were completely faded; it was as though they'd been dropped into a dense jungle. Even the air seemed warmer, soaking into Tori's unsweating skin. Heat was no issue, but if they encountered a more frigid environment, she might be in trouble.

One concern at a time. They followed the collection of breaks in the trees that constituted their route.

"Well, this is officially boring. Should we play a game? Penelope has made me a whiz at twenty questions, assuming all the answers you pick are famous cartoon characters."

How was she this calm? Helen was not only unconcerned with their situation, she was able to get bored? "Seems like we should probably pay attention."

"You can't stay tense the entire time, you'll burn yourself out before nightfall. I've got good ears. Let me handle the scouting. Until then, keeping mentally active will help us continue to stay alert."

Tori wasn't entirely sure how accurate that was; however, she'd begun to feel a headache forming in the base of her skull. The stress of waiting for something to pop out at any moment *was* wearing on her, and this could be their situation for days. Splitting guard duty made enough sense to justify letting herself have a momentary break. Assuming Helen proved to be as sharp a listener as she claimed, they could start trading off on the task.

"I don't know about twenty questions, but I can think of at least one. How do you know so much about these mazes?" Tori considered herself an adept researcher in the meta-human field, and not even she'd retained the myriad of details about Cobblord's various creations.

"Pretty simple: I used to be a reporter who covered the meta-human beat. Writing about new crimes requires putting them in context with what's come before, so a lot of the job was research based." Helen looked almost wistful, though given her age, the job couldn't have come more than a few years prior. "Nowadays, I'm mostly on the business side, running some self-owned stuff and staying afloat. I still like to keep up with meta-human events, though—can't quite kick the habit."

Although Tori didn't let her eyes go wide or loudly gulp, the sentiment still ran through her. A reporter who specialized in meta-humans, with a wide base of historical knowledge? Helen was essentially the worst person

to be paired with while trying to secretly use abilities. Not to mention, her being a history buff meant she would absolutely know quite a bit about Fornax. If Tori fucked up truly spectacularly, it was possible for her to give away both their secrets. Better to steer the topic away from things like metas.

“Entrepreneur, huh? I’ve got ambitions in that direction, too.”

“Not happy at Vendallia?” Helen asked.

On reflex, Tori shrugged. “It’s fine for now, just not what I see for myself long-term. I like a little more excitement than Ivan.” It didn’t hurt to reemphasize his cover as a boring middle manager.

Helen’s laugh was different this time, lighter, almost familiar in an odd way. “You know, your uncle is more than his job. Ivan might surprise you.”

“I think I can safely say I am past the point of being surprised by anything about Ivan,” Tori told her.

A beat of silence passed before Helen’s reply; she’d tilted her head northward for a half-second. “Anything, huh? So you know that Ivan has a beautiful singing voice?”

Of all the insane things that had happened during their day thus far, that mental image almost caused Tori to trip over her own feet. Her brain had slapped Ivan’s face on one of the Multerion musicals—currently, she was picturing him belting out tunes as the titular character from *Phantom of the Symphony*. It was even more ridiculous than she would have guessed.

“I’m calling bullshit,” Tori declared.

“Call it all you want, but I’m right.” Helen didn’t slow down; however, she did shift their angle slightly, moving them to the right side of the path. “When Penelope was a baby, she was the fussiest sleeper you’ve ever met. I was on my own, a little out of my depth, and Ivan came by to help. Sometimes, he would sing her lullabies if she started to cry.”

The mental musical faded, replaced by the thought of Ivan leaning over a crib. Oddly, this image aligned far more naturally with her understanding of the man. When it came to his children, Ivan had no sense of embarrassment; their happiness and safety far outranked such selfish concepts. If singing made his kids happy, he’d have done it, just like he bumbled around the dance floor last night. Evidently, it was a skill he didn’t mind sharing with any infant in his care.

But pleasant an image as that was, it opened up an entirely new topic for discussion. “Wait, I thought you met Ivan when he helped out with

Penelope's play. How did he sing to her as a baby?"

"That's a very good question, Tori. Unfortunately, I'm going to have to request we table it for now. Based on their movements, in less than a minute, we're going to have company." Helen halted their walk, pointing to a large section of trees that were just beginning to wobble.

"Brace yourself. We're about to see this labyrinth's claws."

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## Chapter 78

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It only took a few hours to reach the stone tower where Trey, Yuri, and the rest of the kids were waiting. Had the cluster not been led by a man who'd secretly scouted the entire area and killed every hazard in their path, the simple trek would have taken triple that time, but none of the children suspected a thing as they ran to rejoin their friends. To them, it had simply seemed like the hike they'd already been prepared for, albeit in a scary situation.

"Oh my God, Yuri, they're okay!" Trey called from his position over to Yuri, who was in an identical spot on the other side of the tower. They'd posted lookouts, in case surprises came calling. Ivan wasn't sure if it was the program they headed or these two in particular, but he was glad to have competent help. Given the way this weekend was shaking out, that might well be the only lucky break he was going to get.

Unlike the others, Beth didn't run off to her friends, though she did wave to them. Her hand was gripping Ivan's, he could feel her elevated heart rate thudding away. Worse, he could sense her tension as Beth put all she had into focusing. This was scary, a sudden shift in the expected, and when Beth grew afraid, her blades tended to come out. Rather than worry the others, she was clinging to her father, trying with all her might to keep the silver weapons contained. Ivan's heart might have burst from pride, if it weren't already boiling in fury at whoever had *dared* to make his daughter so fearful.

"Look at that, we got here safely," Ivan told Beth. Still holding her hand, they headed toward Trey, who was walking in their direction. In

unknown terrain, it was best to avoid loud noises like yelling whenever possible. “Is everyone accounted for?”

The relief on Trey’s face as he watched the children pour in spoiled the answer. “We’ll have to do a head count on your group, but I think we’ve got all the kids.” A shadow of fear suddenly crossed. “Wait, where’s the other cluster leader and her helper?”

“Across the track when we were getting lifted. Every inch of separation got magnified in the descent—you and I weren’t very far apart, and it still took hours to get here. Given their distance, it’s safe to say we probably won’t see them before this place shatters and sets us free.” Ivan noted the fear in Trey’s face; unfortunately, there wasn’t much mollification to be offered. Worrying about Helen was like fearing a dandelion: the circumstances where such sentiments were warranted virtually didn’t exist.

Several small forms, those from his cluster, were gathering up now that they recognized their leader. Loyce stuck her head up like a prairie dog, trying to see over the others. “Where’s Miss Helen?”

“She’s perfectly fine, off with Tori exploring this strange place.” Gently, Ivan sank down to a knee, eyeline with the kids. “I know everyone is scared right now, and understandably so. We’ve all been transported to a strange land. But keep things in perspective, too. Has anyone seen any sorts of animals or creatures?”

The shaking heads were as he’d expected, given his speedy slaughter, but it was also a way to make sure nothing had slipped his notice. Thankfully, it seemed he’d been thorough enough in the initial purge. Soon, there would be more. Ivan needed to get them all hunkered down safely before he went out again; each wave would be stronger than what came prior, meaning the fights would take longer.

“There you go, then. We’re in an odd location, but not necessarily a dangerous one. Helen and Tori will be fine. Soon, this place will run out of power and deposit us safely back on the ground. Until then, why don’t we take the opportunity to be proper Starscouts? Has anyone tried to identify the local flora, started sketching our surroundings, or begun work on shelter?”

Both the kids and Trey seemed surprised by the notion. They’d been so caught up in the shock of what happened, they’d yet to plan for survival. That needed to change immediately, both for actual logistics and to keep the

kids from panicking. Having a task to focus on made situations like this more bearable; the other option was sitting around worrying all day.

“Let’s start breaking up based on the skills we feel best in, then your cluster leaders can find appropriate ways for everyone to help out. Take care not to overexert yourselves. I’m unsure how long it will be until we find snacks.” Ivan scanned the area once more, noting a bright orange spot amongst the emerald green of the grass. “I don’t suppose the water jug actually managed to keep its contents when crossing over?”

“Yuri was holding on to it, trying to weigh herself down, and inadvertently kept the top pinned,” Trey explained. “But we only brought enough to cool the kids down post-run. Even with rationing and the smaller bottles, people will get thirsty, fast.”

Another problem added to the list. At least for now, they had something to drink. Food was another matter. In theory, they would all be fine for days before the true negatives of starvation set in; however, that didn’t stop the pain and discomfort. Good kids or not, that was going to hinder them, to say nothing of morale. Nothing Ivan had killed looked especially edible, nor would he have trusted these materials, anyway.

In almost any other circumstances, Ivan would have slipped away into the forest, hunting down Tori and Helen to help them put an end to this. But between Beth and the rest of her cluster, he just couldn’t. They would be defenseless, and with no way of knowing how long Helen would take, he was equally ignorant on the number of threats that would come sniffing around this area. Try as he might to think of another way, Ivan’s only choice was to trust the others while he protected the kids.

“I don’t expect we’ll be here more than a day, at the most,” Ivan replied. “These tend to wind down long before then. Just to be safe, let’s plan for two days with the water rationing.” That would be stretching things thin as it was. If the others took any longer than that, he’d have to risk getting more directly involved. He’d never tried to teleport out from one of Cobblord’s creations. It very well might work, but it could also trigger some sort of volcanic meltdown. Far from a first resort, but if kids started getting dehydrated to the point of danger, risks might become necessary.

A squeeze on Ivan’s hand brought his focus back to Beth, who was chewing on her bottom lip, despite how her parents had tried to break that nervous habit. Eyes locked on the forest, she was steeling herself for something, gathering her nerve. At last, Beth turned her gaze to Ivan.

“I can... I’m going to cut some firewood. We don’t know what the night temperature will be, or if there are any animals out. A fire can be useful for warmth, protection, and cooking, if we find food.”

It was the first time Beth had even proposed the idea of using her powers outside of the courses she took for control. She didn’t even call upon her blades in private, let alone around other people, especially her friends. But she wanted to help, and saw something she could do that no one else could.

Few things terrified Ivan like his daughter’s kindness. He’d seen that same trait abused and twisted in others by no end of opportunistic shits. For a long time, he feared the tendency would lead to her becoming a victim. Then she grew older, began showing some of Janet’s wits, along with perhaps Ivan’s own stubbornness, which eased his concern slightly. But since the change, Ivan’s fear had only intensified. Kind, willful, smart, loyal, and with meta-human powers, Beth had all the makings of a future cape. He wasn’t sure what to do if that day came, how to react, what to say—any of it. What Ivan did know was that, in this moment, his daughter could turn something she was ashamed of into a way to help. She had a chance to be proud of her difference.

“Why don’t you wait a few moments? Then I can go over with you, help haul what you chop. Have to be careful around the woods until we know for sure there’s nothing out there.” He squeezed her hand, watching as fear and determination mixed to form an unexpected happiness on her face. The idea still worried her, but she’d made up her mind. No one knew better than her father how closed that meant the issue now was.

To his surprise, she pulled him closer, lowering her voice to a whisper. “Daddy, what happens if this doesn’t let us out in a day? I researched these labyrinths for a class project once. I don’t think they’re on a timer.”

As diplomatic a way as he could hope for a near-teen to call out his obvious lies. “I know, but they might as well be. The capes always handle these things in short order. Besides that, if things did get truly desperate, I still wouldn’t worry for a moment. You think someone can mess with this organization and not stir *her* up?”

He expected to have to sell the next line, yet it came out surprisingly natural. Or perhaps not so surprising, given the sentiment he was expressing. It was, after all, admiration for her strength; as the only one to defeat him, he had no choice but to acknowledge her power.



“Lodestar will save us, if it comes to that. In fact, I bet she’s already on the case.”



Sort of like if a bull and a mountain lion interbred, was Tori’s first thought. Gray, stone-like skin coated the lithe body as it strolled across the grass, with stretches of green foliage filling in the various joints. Each leg ended in a paw with claws the size of kitchen knives. The head included a snout with irregular, sharp teeth, and a pair of small horns better used for a quick slice than a full goring. Considering that even on all fours it nearly came up to her hip, this thing was hauling some heft around, too, no matter how graceful those steps appeared.

In a split second, Tori had to make the first of many choices. Assume it was aggressive and come out swinging, or wait to see if they roused this thing’s particular appetite. Were she in a real jungle, the latter option would have been more appealing—avoiding conflict wherever possible was generally a smart call. Except they weren’t in the actual world, with animals that moved as instinct and nature guided. They were in a giant crafted maze, filled with things solely here to kill them. One way or another, this creature would be Tori’s enemy. Waiting around for a fair fight was some stupid cape bullshit.

No sooner had it stepped fully out of the trees than Tori struck, darting in from the side and kicking it full force in what would be the ribs on a real animal. In mix of good and bad news, she visibly made an impact, eliciting a sharp yelp from her target. Unfortunately, the throbbing pain in her foot made it clear that damage hadn’t only flowed one way. Until she could shift her foot to fire form, Tori was looking at fractured, if not broken, toes.

That might have been worth the trade, had her target been suitably driven off. Instead, she appeared to have only provoked it; snout dipping low as it angled those horns toward her. Tori readied herself to dodge, hoping there would be a chance to strike in the counter. What she was utterly unprepared for was the axe kick Helen dropped onto the beast’s back. Unlike Tori’s attack, this drew far more than a yelp—stone shattered as it crumpled down slightly.

“Remember when I said we had to table your question? This is me untabling it.” Helen didn’t let up, scooping an arm under her opponent’s mid-section and flipping it onto its injured back, causing more damage in the process. “While I don’t really broadcast it, the truth is, I’m a meta-human. That’s how Ivan and I know each other.” She threw one elbow to the chest of her downed enemy, causing it to stop stirring. “Normal as I look, my body is physically fine-tuned to peak human condition. Meaning I can hit hard and well, when the need arises.”

Much as that opened up more questions than it answered, Tori did feel her hopes for survival increase substantially. If Helen had even some baseline physical abilities, it would make caring for her easier. That was the hope, at least, until the trees rustled and four more of the bullpanthers stepped into view.

Against this many, there was no time to think, especially as one charged right for Helen. Tori moved on pure instinct, fully giving herself over to the fight. As the bullpanther drew near, it opened its mouth, like it planned to chew off a piece of Helen. With only a passing thought of Deacon, Tori jammed her arm into its open mouth, fist already turning into fire. It was clear that getting out of this meant using all her tools, fire abilities included. Knowing that she was with a fellow meta-human, Tori barely even registered that she’d decided to let this secret out before she was blasting the monster full of flames.

The blaze did little to the stone, obviously. However, the foliage growing in the cracks and joints immediately caught fire. As it did, the bullpanther slowed, wobbling slightly, before starting to come apart. So the greenery was the glue keeping these things together. Tori set a grim smile to her face as she pulled her hand free, leaving the still-smoking husk behind.

“There’s a chance I might have a secret of my own.”

Helen was already shifting position, covering Tori’s other side. “Well then, what’s say we give these things a proper introduction to ourselves. I could use a good stretch.”

In spite of how mad the situation was, Tori barely suppressed a morose chuckle at the approaching creatures. It wasn’t often she had targets to truly let loose on. Perhaps she’d manage to have a little fun before this ordeal was over.

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## Chapter 79

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Between Helen's fists and Tori's flames, the remaining three bullpanthers presented minimal challenge. Tori roasted the first, cooking off all the flora acting as its sinew, while Helen directed another's charge into a tree, its horn catching on the bark. She used the opening to kick its body mercilessly, until it crumpled down into a heap of rubble. The last one didn't attempt to flee—one more small reminder to Tori that they weren't dealing with sentient creatures, merely automated defenses.

Almost offhandedly, she torched it, wondering what tricks she'd use on the first enemy they encountered without such an obvious weakness. Assuming the challenges only got stronger, she'd probably have to deal with a few full-stone opponents, at the least. On the plus side, Tori was no longer on her own for combat.

Watching Helen move was a little disconcerting. Most meta-humans with physical augmentation leaned on that trait too hard, rather than training up their actual skills. They were easily marked by their simplistic styles and grandiose movements. Not Helen. She was quick, efficient, and brutal. There was no mistaking this for some newly turned meta who'd taken a few self-defense courses. Helen had experience. A lot of it, if Tori trusted her instincts—something she was hesitant on for the moment. Helen had slipped this secret past Tori without tripping so much as a single suspicion, after all.

With the last enemy downed, Helen wiped hair from her eyes, eventually giving up and digging around in her pockets for a band to hold it

back. “Nice moves! I’d make a ‘hot stuff’ joke, but I doubt I can come up with anything you haven’t heard already. Still, pretty impressive fighting.”

“I was going to say the same to you.” Now that she’d stopped her assault, Helen looked perfectly mundane again. Tori could almost have deluded herself into thinking the whole thing imagined, if not for the rocky remains surrounding them. “You sure don’t move like a reporter or business owner.”

“Talking is fine, but we should move as we do it. Ticking clock of our supplies, plus the mazes get uppity if you stay in one place too long. A labyrinth is meant to be experienced. All the systems are designed to push people toward participating.”

No sooner had Tori learned this new fact than her mind leapt across the canyon to where Ivan and the kids would be hunkered down. It wasn’t the threats overtaking him that concerned her—no automated trap was strong enough to kill Fornax. What worried Tori was how efficiently Ivan could fight while hiding his secret. Between keeping Beth safe and getting to continue being Ivan, Tori knew without question which it was that he would pick, just like she knew losing that part of himself would hurt for the rest of his life.

More importantly, however, Tori caught on to something else. “Hang on. So the labyrinth pushes harder on people who try not to play along, which you already knew. And you’re still not worried in the slightest about those kids?”

This was as close as Tori dared to push, and even that was honestly overstepping. Her only saving detail was that she hadn’t actually said his name. She watched as Helen pondered the question, turning it around mentally, before finally allowing a gentle smile to land upon her face.

“Yes, Tori, it’s okay. I know who he is. I know what he can do. And I know he will use every ounce of that power to defend those children. Because a person is more than their reputation, more than their past, more than the facts others might think they know. But most of all, because Beth is there watching. He will *never* let himself fall short when his children’s eyes are upon him. With her present, I’m not sure he’d lose to anyone, even Lodestar.”

Relief cascaded through Tori as the weight of Ivan’s secret fell away. With as much as they had to deal with already, the simple act of being able to genuinely discuss the situation felt like a huge leap forward. Now that

her powers were revealed and Ivan's identity acknowledged, Tori could finally put her energy fully into beating this labyrinth, rather than doing so with one hand and her fire abilities tied behind her back.

"That is great to hear, but word to the wise, I wouldn't drop the Lodestar line around Ivan. 'Nobody beats Lodestar' is practically his unofficial motto." Tori heard something like a snorted snicker slip out of Helen's mouth, but when she turned back, the bespectacled woman wore a totally neutral expression.

"You can't blame him too much for that. If you were the best at something for years and years, then met the only other person who could actually challenge you, even if they eventually won, it would be hard not to admit their talent. After all, to belittle that person's skill is to belittle everyone below them, as well." Helen held up a finger, and they came to a sudden halt. She stood like that for a moment, then nodded to the left, taking them along a slightly rougher path of the forest.

Shoving aside some thick branches, Helen held them in place long enough for Tori to slip through. "It's totally okay if you don't want to discuss it, but may I ask how you ended up with fire abilities? Some metas like the chance to open up, others not so much—completely your choice."

With a grunt, Tori roughly tore back a shrub trying to dig its thorns into her legs. Her injured foot was throbbing more and more over time; soon, she'd start limping noticeably. Using fire was one thing, letting on that she could turn into it another. Then again, Helen already knew Ivan's secret and the bulk of Tori's: what did one more aspect matter? Especially compared to slowing down their trip when they were already on a pretty serious clock.

"Lab accident," Tori replied, motioning for Helen to slow down. She pushed her way through the undergrowth until Tori could brace herself against a dense tree trunk. Lifting her right foot, she made a mental note of thanks to the guild for providing a phase-shifting-friendly version of this uniform. "Was messing with something a bit out of my league, things went awry, and when the dust settled, I could do this."

On cue, her entire lower leg shifted into living fire. As the nerve endings vanished, so did the ache, permitting Tori a long sigh of unexpected relief. That might have been hurting more than her brain wanted to admit. Only when the pain vanished could it be truly appreciated.

Helen was staring, fascinated by the transformation. "That's interesting. Historically, every stable elemental phase-shift like that has been done with

some aspect of magic; never seen one from a purely scientific-based source. Orion was the closest, but he had a little bit of everything.” She made no move to draw closer or examine the phenomena, yet her gaze also didn’t leave the burning appendage.

“Guess you can consider me a... trailblazer.”

Helen laughed, probably more out of politeness than actual humor. “That joke almost makes me wonder if you and Ivan aren’t actually related after all.”

Not wanting to dive back into anything around that topic, Tori opted for a rapid conversational redirect. “What about you? How did you get... super-strength, it looked like?”

“More maxed out, than super,” Helen corrected. “The maximum potential my genes held. Think of humanity like cars being made on an assembly line. There’s a plan for each, but some get put together better than others—usually just by luck of the draw. My body is the equivalent of someone building a custom car. Every detail has been polished, every efficiency achieved. Blood pumps increased oxygen, muscles recover more quickly. I’m flexible, fast, and so on. Basically every advantage my body had the potential for has been realized, and every weakness eliminated.”

That was a fascinating power all right, if limited in scale. Human boundaries meant Helen could never tangle with the true powers of the world, but day to day, her ability probably came in a lot handier than controlling flames. There was, however, one discrepancy that Tori couldn’t help noting as she returned her foot to physical form.

“Perfectly built, huh?”

“Well, the aesthetics are open to opinion. I’m not saying it straightened the bump in my nose or gave my hair effortless volume,” Helen said. “More functionally perfect.”

“Weird then, that someone with all those advantages would have subpar eyesight.” Tori reached up, tapping the side of her face where glasses would have rested, were she wearing them.

To her surprise, the revelation was greeted by an increase in cheer from Helen, who jiggled her own spectacles in response. “Could be a fashion choice. Can’t a gal accessorize?”

“Could be,” Tori agreed. “I guess I should ask you same thing you asked me: want to talk about where your powers came from?”

“I very much do not.” Helen managed to keep all the pleasantness still in her voice, while also instantly shutting down that line of conversation. “The experience was far from a happy one, not the sort of thing to get bogged down in when our plates are already so full.”

That more or less killed the discussion for the next few minutes. Instead, they focused on making headway through the brush. Overhead, the artificial sky was shifting, its false sun beginning to move toward the horizon. Odds were good that this place had some sort of day and night cycle, which probably meant things would get more dangerous once the sun fell. Tori had nothing to base that assumption on, yet it felt immediately right, the way these sorts of things were meant to work. Perhaps she was simply learning to think like a villain.

After half an hour of silent trekking, they broke through a cluster of trees to find something new. More stones, though these weren’t moving—for the moment. Overgrown by what looked to be decades of grass and weeds stood a stone arch, leading into what would have been matching stone walls, if not for the broken sections causing sizable gaps. Further along, the breaks grew less frequent, as the structure appeared to lead to a large building made of the same material. While there was more forest along the edges, Tori felt confident that between them, they could cut a path around the side.

“Pretty sure we can skip this, if we work at it.”

“I’m almost certain you’re right, except we can’t.” Helen pointed to the huge obstacle, the place their route had obviously been leading toward.

“Remember, this is a game. Don’t play along, and things get more complicated. Angering the maze just risks making our own job harder, or causing surprises for Ivan and the others.”

The part of Tori that had always been drawn to discovery and invention, the piece of her that compelled the breaking down of various electronics to see how they worked, rebelled at such an idea. Her mind burned, seeing opportunities for efficiency and being denied them. Tori wanted to rip this place down to the screws until she understood the mechanics behind every blade of grass and puff of wind. Instead, she swallowed her annoyance and looked at the path laid out for her, the one she was trapped on.

“Any idea what will be inside?” If she couldn’t go at this her own way, Tori would have to settle for being as forewarned as possible.

“Could be a fight, a puzzle, a trap, a test, or an empty building just to mess with us. Probably not that last one—I don’t feel especially lucky today—but it shouldn’t be too bad. Escalating challenges and all that.”

Tori couldn’t believe her own feet as they walked through the stone arch, plodding down the path to an obvious trap. “Walking into a dangerous situation with no idea what we’re facing and with innocent people counting on our success. You know, this is probably the closest I’ll ever get to being a cape, thank goodness.”

“It does seem to be a calling that isn’t for everyone.” Helen paused, running a hand along the stone wall briefly, like she was checking for something. Whatever it was went unfound; she resumed their pilgrimage after a few moments. “Although, you might be more inclined to it than you realize. In my experience, there does tend to be a common trait that all capes share.”

“Corny taste in code names?”

Helen had to visibly bite back a chuckle at that. “Not quite. The inability to stand idly by. Capes are the sort of people who see an event they can’t stand happening and do something about it. Even if they might not be powerful enough, even if they don’t know the people involved. The ones who can act, and do—that’s the pool of people I’d look to for future superheroes. And you definitely don’t strike me as someone to linger on the sidelines when she’s compelled to action.”

“Maybe so, but there’s no way you’ll catch me in one of those ridiculous outfits.” As far as counters went, it wasn’t an especially strong one, mostly because Helen was right. The only thing she’d missed was that there was another avenue for those who wanted to shape the world into something better. Not all of those willing to act went to the side of the capes. The makings of a superhero and a villain were only a few details apart.

From the building, both women heard a loud noise rise up, like the sound of something very heavy thudding onto the ground. Exchanging a single look, they lowered their stances, hunkering down behind the walls for as much cover as they would allow. Now that they knew there was potential company, they silently made their way along the broken stone hallway, toward the unseen challenge awaiting them inside.



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## Chapter 80

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Beth turned out to be a big help, as she was just about the only sharp element present in the camp, outside of a few rogue pocket knives. Her silver blades sliced effortlessly through the pseudo-trees, ringless interiors exposed as they cut cleanly in twain. For the larger denizens of the forest, Beth focused on shearing away branches, stretching her mercurial slithering weapons several feet up.

Despite Wade running analyses and the AHC teaching her control, there were still no clues about Beth's power. What it was, precisely, or where it had come from, no one had any notion. They weren't even sure what that silvery metal was composed of. So far, there had yet to be so much as a single fleck of residue to examine. The only way to test the blades would be in person, and Ivan hadn't yet figured out a way to slip a guild examination by Beth. Sweet and trusting though she was, every now and then, the girl had a habit of noticing more than one might expect.

By the time they headed back, Beth had honestly cut more wood than they'd possibly need for their planned stay. She'd found something of a rhythm by the end, so Ivan had just let her go. Having a task to focus on beat whatever awaited them when she was done: more sitting around. The boredom would be an insidious enemy the longer this dragged on. Without distraction, it was all the easier to dwell on fear and hunger.

Hauling the wood in his arms—more than he'd have normally risked carrying in less distracting circumstances—Ivan quickly took note of all the kids milling about. With a rough camp established, they were getting bored. The mental part of this would be harder than dealing with the automated

monsters; he couldn't punch away a group of kids' growing unrest, even knowing it might eventually lead to panic.

They had to keep the scouts engaged and mentally active, doing more than thinking about their situation. Having them run around or burn energy was the easiest fix, but one they couldn't rely on with such limited supplies. Higher activity meant sweat, which would lead to emptying their pitiful water reserves all the faster, quickening everyone's panic. Ivan didn't have a solution, nor did one jump to mind immediately. This was far past his area of expertise, even as a parent. The best he could do was handle one issue at a time and hope Helen was moving fast.

Ivan was barely done setting down the wood when he spotted Yuri zipping over. She was walking briskly, without trying to appear in a hurry—performative for the scouts, obviously. Whatever the issue, it was only intended for adult ears.

"Why don't you go check on everyone?" Ivan proposed to Beth, clapping off the final splinters from his hands. "Mallory and Caden are both unsettled by surprises. We should make sure they're holding up all right."

She responded with a mock-salute, smile fixed in place, happy to help. "Can do!"

By the time Yuri reached Ivan, Beth was already halfway across the camp; her lack of care for optics meant that she could scramble along at great speeds. Rather than let Yuri broach her topic, Ivan motioned her to follow slightly, getting them to the edge of camp. Not terribly subtle, but he suspected that would be a growing theme as the ordeal wore on.

Eyes to the sky, Ivan tried to estimate how long they'd been inside the orb already. This place's night wasn't too far off, though how that corresponded to time in the real world would be total speculation. Anything that folded space this much usually messed with the chronoflow as well. No matter how he squinted, it had been more than a little while. Long enough that soon, he'd need to start worrying about monsters again.

"Hey, it was Ivan, right?"

"Correct, although I certainly wouldn't have held forgetting against you, considering the circumstances." He noted the awkward shift in her movement and the way her eventual stance favored the back foot. Not a topic she was looking forward to, then.

"Listen, I was talking with Trey, and it seems like maybe sitting around isn't the best idea. If there's nothing out there, we should be hunting for an

exit.”

Having kids had taught Ivan a tremendous amount of lessons, one of the most salient of which was patience. Yuri wasn't stupid, merely afraid and inexperienced. She'd been hurled from her comfort zone, and didn't even have the luxury of panic with all the scouts looking to her for support. Chiding her would get them nowhere; however, Ivan also had to align her thinking. Resources were too thin for major mistakes.

“Much as it might feel that way, I promise you, we are following the correct strategy.”

More weight on the back foot, yet she didn't actually shift her position. “How can you be so sure about that? We've got no capes, no idea if anyone else even knows we're in trouble, and the only two people actually trying to get us out of here weren't exactly substantial looking. Someone like Trey would have better luck.”

“If Trey's strength is so vital, perhaps it's best used to protect the children.”

“From what?” Yuri demanded. “There's nothing here. We've scouted all around the tower, totally empty. We're wasting someone who could be helping to get us out.”

Given that Ivan had slaughtered the first wave of enemies, then refused to move on, whatever came next was guaranteed to be more troublesome. Not by Ivan's standards, but strong enough that Trey would be pulped the first time he met one of the incoming creatures. If he let the man leave, it was a death sentence. While that was a sacrifice Ivan would make if the situation demanded, they were quite a way from reaching that point yet. More people to watch the kids would make Ivan's work protecting them easier, and besides, he didn't dislike Yuri or Trey. Wanting to help wasn't bad, they just lacked understanding on how to best apply their strengths to the situation.

“Perhaps, or perhaps the monsters here only come out at night.” Ivan pointed up to the fake sky, where the not-sun was drifting toward the horizon. “Given that we're surrounded by a forest, nocturnal threats would make sense.”

“It's not a real forest,” Yuri pointed out. She pressed her hand against a nearby tree, eyes narrowing at the sensation. Off, somehow, in a way that couldn't quite be articulated any more than it could be denied.

Ivan nodded his agreement. “But it aims to be. It mimics one in appearance, so schedule makes just as much sense. My point is, before Trey goes off on his own, perhaps he should wait out one night with the group. Help soothe the kids, make sure we’re really as alone as we think.”

Her eyes followed his to the artificial sky, noting the way their version of a sun had shifted. Without looking, he could hear her stance change, her feet more solidly rooted.

“I guess it doesn’t make much sense to start out in unfamiliar terrain with night approaching. But if it passes without incident, he’s going to head out. We don’t need this many people to keep the kids corralled. Getting out of here needs to be the top priority.”

“Let’s worry about making it through the night first,” Ivan suggested. “To that effect, my daughter procured us quite a bit of firewood. Perhaps we should get the scouts to work building a proper pit. It shouldn’t strain them much, and will occupy their time.”

Yuri caught the idea quickly, already on board. “Fire also doesn’t hurt in case there are any animals out here, or we find a water source to purify.”

Her optimism felt misplaced, but then, Ivan had never been in this particular creation of Cobblord’s. It was always possible he’d built the model to be sustainable. If nothing else, Ivan wasn’t going to take away her hope. That was something vital they needed to cling to, especially as time here wore on.

While Yuri headed back to camp, Ivan turned his attention from the sky to the forest beyond. It wouldn’t be long now, and the next wave would come. His original plan had been to slip away in the hecticness, crush their assault before it ever drew close, and then return before being missed. Unfortunately, going that route had a strong chance of getting Trey killed. More than that, he’d already spotted a few scouts poking around the borders of the camp, exploring their boundaries the way children always did. Ivan couldn’t be sure he’d caught every trap and danger, so they needed to be kept out of the woods—a much harder task with nothing to be afraid of.

To keep this working, Ivan was going to have to let the scouts know that there was danger in these woods—all without letting them get hurt, and ideally while keeping his own identity hidden. This was why Ivan loathed situations in which he had to protect people; his skills were never suited for it. Everything about Ivan was built for destruction. At his peak, he could

make natural disasters shit their pants. The most he could do now was make a plan, hope for the best, and trust in Helen.

Though he really hoped she wasn't taking her sweet time with ending this.



It was extremely tempting to use super-speed. Make an excuse, slip ahead of Tori, change, and blast through the rest of this labyrinth before they missed what counted as dinner at the End of Summer Shindig. Helen had two major hang-ups staying her speedy feet, however, the largest of which was not being sure of how the labyrinth would react. Zipping through the experience seemed like the sort of thing that would trip countermeasures; no big deal if they fell on her, *very* big deal if they impacted the kids. Even past the safety concerns, Helen might have still kept to this strategy, if not for the lack of clues.

Right now, she had zero. Well, that wasn't entirely true. Helen could rule out guild involvement, barring another coup attempt, which seemed early so soon after the last. The organization was much too smart to take this kind of swing, and against Ivan's own children... no, definitely not the guild. The AHC was out, as well. The only one who might do something like this was Vernon, and he'd never outsource that kind of work. His pride wouldn't bear it.

Taking those two off the board, Helen was working blind. She had no idea what this was about, the target, the goals, any of it. Until she understood what was happening, it would be difficult to prevent repeats from occurring. Knowing an enemy's plans made thwarting them vastly easier.

So Helen trod on next to Tori, never letting on just how powerful she could be if the need arose. Watching Ivan's apprentice had been fascinating. It was strange to see the places where his guidance had plainly left its mark. No wonder the two got along: they were emotionally closed off peas in their sardonic little pod. Yet Helen could also see Tori's differences: the way she examined every detail, the careful thought constantly at work behind those brown eyes. Ivan's guidance had always come from his gut; he trusted the

impulses that had kept him alive above virtually any other source. It was what made Fornax so unpredictable, and so interesting.

Up the eroded steps inside the building—which was an interesting design choice in itself, considering this place wasn't actually ancient. Or was it? Helen didn't know if Cobblord made these to look distressed, or if he built them new and then found a way to age them. Either way, the effect was impressive—a few of the stones even gave way under Helen's feet near the end of the staircase.

At the top, there was only a single archway open. The rest had been blocked off by coincidentally fallen rubble, adding weight to the idea that the scene was designed like this. Expecting rocks to fall in a certain pattern was a stretch, even for a craftsman of Cobblord's caliber.

Outside the door, Tori hesitated, giving Helen a chance to put herself directly in front. Secrets were well and good when one could keep them, but she wasn't going to risk letting Tori be hurt. Hiding the fact that she was Lodestar wasn't allowed to grow more important than actually *being* Lodestar, a personal rule she'd settled on a long time ago.

Despite the shadowy appearance, there was no mildew or dankness as they entered the new hallway, just more stones as dry as those outside. Nicer on their noses, but not a great sign for this place having any drinkable water. If there were any, it probably would have been used for ambiance. As it was, the hall still cast a foreboding aura: long, looming, with sharp stones jutting out at odd angles. With every few steps, sconces near the ceiling burst into flame, lighting the way ahead.

Finally, they left the hallway as it opened into a vast chamber. At least fifty feet high, with odd breaks all along the walls, it appeared to be entirely empty, save only for a large metal pit directly in the center. As an old hand at these things, Helen wasn't surprised when a stone slab dropped into place behind them, blocking their exit. Nor was she ruffled when pitch-black flames suddenly burst forth from the room's pit. Not even the sudden voice that filled the room truly caught her off guard.

The words it spoke, on the other hand, shocked Helen so greatly she very nearly let out an un-Lodestar-like curse.

"Welcome to the first chamber of testing. It is a pleasure to see you've made it this far... Fornax."

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## Chapter 81

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It felt like the stale air had been sucked from the room. Both women tensed, albeit for quite different reasons, as the booming voice continued to echo around them.

“Surprised? Did you think it was coincidence that you’d ended up here, or perhaps that we were after your little pet?”

Tori’s hands tried to ball up, but she denied them. Getting riled up on someone else’s terms didn’t suit her need for the moment. She had to be clear-headed until there was a chance to find this motherfucker, *then* the payback could start.

“No, Fornax, this was all for you. I’d have preferred peace—we never meant to steal your toy—but I know how your guild feels about grudges, to say nothing of your own reputation. My green little helper all but begged me not to mention that she was the one tasked with trapping you. Silly thing still believes you’ll be a threat afterward. Consider this a warning, a show of force, and a threat. Because we know about you. We know, for example, that right now, you’ve almost certainly been barreling through this maze, fearful of what will happen to those kids while you’re gone. To say nothing of your sweet Beth.”

“Oh *shit*.” Tori didn’t mean to speak; the words came out entirely on their own. Glancing over, she found a severe expression on Helen’s face.

While outwardly she had better control, Helen’s internal reaction was more or less on par with Tori’s. Ivan was generally dependable, predictable, a functioning member of society. Except when people went for his family. That was when Fornax showed he was capable of more than wanton

slaughter; hunting people for vengeance had been that monster's entire purpose, the inferno of hate that fueled him. Attempting to provoke that side of Ivan, even as a bluff, was absolutely fucking insane. The trail of destruction he'd leave would be horrific, if she didn't stop him first.

"I'm sure by now you've discovered that any attempts at skipping sections, teleportation, and strong warping of the chronoflow will all trigger more of Cobblord's pets to appear. What you likely haven't learned is that in each occurrence, the same enemies spawn near the starting area, where you'll have had to leave those children undefended. We wanted to see what you could do when properly motivated; you understand. That's also why that entire area will get rapidly more dangerous as the hours pass. Perhaps you left your pet to buy them a little time, but she won't last long. You need to hurry, Fornax. Hurry if you want to save them. And remember that this was nothing more than a display. We know your name. We know your loved ones."

The flames roared suddenly, rising up from the pit as the voice reached a crescendo that bordered on a hiss. "Stay out of my way!"

With that, the fire vanished, though Tori noted there were still lit sconces showing them an empty room. More than just that, there was a creaking and rustling coming from all around them. Tori strained her eyes, trying to see into walls' dark voids where the light refused to reach. No luck, and while Tori did love both cursing and darkness, in this instance, she decided to flick on a light. Forming a fireball in her hand, Tori reared back and chunked it through the air, sending it blazing along to splash roughly against one of the opening's corners. From the brief flash, she could make out more rocks and a splash of green, which likely meant foliage. Those were secondary observations, however. The most important factor was apparent the moment her light had landed: movement. Something was moving in those walls.

"Stay calm." Helen's voice was steady, a sharp contrast to the shifting surroundings. "This is going to be a fight. We have to accept that and adapt." She wished she felt half as sure as she sounded. Someone was picking a fight with Fornax, and that was nuts, but the truly crazy part was that Helen still had no idea who it was. She had firsthand experience with every major threat to attack the world for the last few decades, the sorts of people who even *could* come at Fornax and the guild, none of whom fit the bill. Not like this, and not that voice.



Reorienting herself, Tori put her back to Helen, making sure they had eyes on all angles. “Any thoughts on what we’re facing?”

“Something manageable. Remember, Cobblord’s skills might be for sale, but he’s consistent with his art, and that means an escalating challenge.” The part Helen was leaving out was that this was a sliding scale built with Fornax in mind, but she’d deal with that once it mattered. “Based on the layout, I’d expect multiple attacks coming from different directions, probably triggered as soon as we head toward the pit to examine it for clues.”

That lined up with Tori’s observations, so it was as fine a working theory as any. “Gotcha. Okay, so what’s in our favor? That whole monologue was for...” Tori’s words faltered, as she suddenly realized just how vague they’d really been when discussing who Ivan was. From what Helen said, she might know it all, or only that he was a meta with a past. No one had actually said the name Fornax. A moment of thought made Tori realize the issue was beyond her control. The voice had called out Beth by name. There was no denying the connection.

“The monologue was for Ivan.” Tori couldn’t bring herself to use *that* name around someone else, even if the cat was freed from its bag. “So whoever made this can’t communicate directly. Hopefully, they can’t see anything either, or make adjustments on the fly. This whole thing was built with the expectation that only one person would be here.”

“Meaning that only one of us needs to go down to trip the attack,” Helen agreed. “Which will be me.”

“I’m not sure—”

Without hesitation, Helen cut her off, noting the way the sounds were getting louder. No matter the circumstances, the labyrinth got antsy when people stood still for too long. “Tori, you hit from a range. I punch and kick. Of the two of us, which can do a better job drawing attention, and which can do better sniping?”

Helen didn’t actually wait for an answer; the speech had gotten her a bit more stirred up than she wanted to let on. It wasn’t just coming after Ivan and Beth, although that did set off some very un-Lodestar-like feelings in her mind. This bastard had done it in the middle of a Starscout event, endangering unknown numbers of innocent children just to piss off and test Ivan. As a cape, it infuriated her, to see them needlessly put at risk. As the

one who'd promised, by context, if not words, that those kids would be safe, Helen was veering dangerously close to getting *truly* pissed off.

When this was done, when the traps were gone and she could move freely, there would be severe repercussions. For the criminal's sake as much as her own fury, because locked away in an AHC jail cell was just about the only place he had an outside chance of surviving Ivan's vengeance.

Until then, she had work to do.

No sooner had her feet touched the center of the main floor than the walls virtually exploded. From within the holes they came, appendages like mossy snakes, as the overgrowth-covered stone struck. Some of the extremities had heavy, blunted ends, like a mace, while others were sporting a mishmash of blades poking out along every angle. Helen leapt out of the way of a mace-arm, watching as it smashed into the corner of some steps, leaving a huge crater in that section of staircase.

A blade-arm wasn't too far behind, and as Helen slid beneath, using her flexibility to pull off an Olympic-level limbo move, she noticed the flashes of red coming from the edge of the room. Tori was firing on the arms, burning off sections of foliage where she could, but it wasn't easy to hit moving targets from her position on the ground. The efforts didn't appear to be bothering the arms, as they continued to focus on Helen.

Dashing across the stone, she managed to zip past two more huge, smashing blows from the mace-arms. One of those, and Helen's secret was out. Her body would use as much power as needed to survive—very rarely a subtle display. Watching the angles of attack, she altered her planned path of movement slightly, a new idea jumping to mind. Glancing over to Tori, Helen noticed that her Starscout assistant was gone. That misconception only lasted until the blast of flame drew Helen's attention to the ceiling.

Since shooting from the ground did shit-all, Tori had elected to go skyward. Whatever hesitations she'd had about hiding her powers were long gone in the wake of that speech. This was no longer a curiosity, or a weird occurrence to puzzle out. Somebody was knowingly swinging against Fornax, against her teacher, against her guild. That changed the stakes, even without the personal aspect. The kidnapping was an accident—didn't make her less mad, but she got it. This was different. This was that bastard looking directly at the organization she was a part of and declaring he wasn't afraid. He was going to learn fear, for the short time he survived; until then, blowtorching his toys was the best outlet Tori could find.

She rained fire down on every slithering stone appendage she could see, targeting the bases where they connected to the wall. This had the benefit of avoiding Helen, who was sticking to the center of the room as she nimbly ducked and dove away from every blow, like a cartoon mouse slipping through her cat's fingers. At least, that was Tori's impression until the crunch.

One of the mace-arms had come down heavily, directly onto the midsection of a blade-arm. Somehow, amidst all the dashing about, Helen had managed to guide the appendages where she wanted them, causing the mechanism to attack itself. The half-shattered blade-arm weakly rose, shaking visibly, and Tori decided this was her chance.

Cutting off her flames, she dropped through the air, firing off an occasional blast for redirection. Just before the end, Tori shot flames from both hands and feet, killing her momentum as she landed on the crushed section of arm. Since there were no points for subtlety, Tori opted to take her speediest strategic option. Digging her arms into the stone and thick moss, she turned her whole body to flames, cascading out and in, catching aflame every piece of greenery she could find. The fire caught at once, racing through the interior of the arm, along with the outside. Tori barely had time to get back into the air before it was cracking, the front section breaking off entirely.

One down, seven to go, by Helen's count. Too many. She looked around the building once more, wracking her brain. No matter what the client wanted, Cobblord maintained his standards. A slug-fest for the first challenge didn't seem fitting, especially considering that this was supposed to be for Fornax. What would he have done, in this setting? Obliterate the arms, obviously. So what next?

Her eyes fell upon the forgotten firepit, and Helen felt it all click. Fornax would break the enemies, only to realize they were just a diversion. The real key would be somewhere he'd likely overlook, costing Fornax precious time and angering him further. It was an assumption that only worked if one knew Fornax by reputation as a mindless brute, rather than the kind of man Ivan really was. Trusting her instincts, Helen altered her planned trajectory.

With Tori overhead throwing flames, the arms were at least slowing down a bit as their greenery burned. Recalculating their speeds, Helen waited a hair longer to break left, sprinting in just near enough to a mace-

arm that it would try to attack. She'd slowly been getting a sense of their range and what provoked a strike; given enough time, Helen could probably have broken most of the appendages with one another. This would be faster, if it panned out. If not, she'd just try something else. As an old friend had once told her: "The real secret to being a cape is just not giving up until you've found a way to win."

As she ran, Helen gauged the arms. The nearest one had blades, but it was currently on fire and would drop down a few feet short. Although a mace-arm was coming from the left, two blade-arms recovering from their last swings blocked a clean angle. Tori was working hard to cook the other blade-wielder, which left the last mace-arm for Helen, just like she wanted. It tracked her as she moved, clearing the blade-arm strike that was two feet short. Right when she slowed, the way a normal person might to take a corner or grab a breath, the arm struck. It slammed down with all of its considerable weight and power, utterly destroying the firepit that Helen had leapt out in front of.

Like a hose with a leak, they could hear the hiss, some unseen element escaping from within the ground where the pit had once stood. As it grew louder, the arms began to sink, the invisible force propelling them draining away. Holding her breath, more for fear of stink than poisoning, Helen walked casually back over the shattered remains of the firepit. Her hair was blown back by the invisible gas, but all the rattling of the rubble made it easy to spot what she was looking for, though she didn't know what it was.

The gem shined a pale red in the light of the flickering sconces, a perfect square, evidently with some sort of charge or magic. That assumption was based off the fact that as soon as Helen laid hands upon it, a door at the other end of the building began to loudly slide open. She watched as Tori came down, landing roughly near one of the now lifeless arms before walking over.

"Figure it out?"

"Yeah. The real target was the firepit all along. Classic double-up: you build something that seems like it's only there for theatricality or ambience, then hide the prize inside." Almost too classic, really. Helen hadn't seen this one used for a good while. "No surprise from someone that still monologues. I mean, they happen, but doing a whole production of one has been out of vogue for decades."

Together, they looked at the jewel, still sparkling slightly in the flickering light of the residual flames spreading across the downed arms. It was Tori who finally said the obvious, unable to see any way around it. "One gem probably means more, right? If it was a key, it might be one and done, but that feels like a component."

"That's my guess. And they'll only get harder from here." Helen tucked the jewel away carefully in her pocket. "But let's look on the bright side. Whoever built this expected Ivan to be on his own. They assumed he'd have to abandon the kids and crack through here at top speed. That means we should be able to finish before food or water become serious issues."

"Except that, while we do, more and more monsters are heading to the area where all the scouts are waiting."

There was something about Helen's smile that tickled Tori's brain. She'd seen one like it before, hadn't she? Kind and warm, but with a hidden laugh just out of sight, like its owner knew a joke nobody else did.

"Monsters that were made to deal with a group of scared children. Whatever threats have been marshalled, they won't even be close to scariest thing out there tonight." That smile brightened, and Tori wished she could just reach in her skull to scratch the gray matter directly.

"Those poor beasties are in no way prepared to face Ivan."

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## Chapter 82

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The forest was moving. From this distance, that was how it looked: trees swaying in a wind that didn't exist. Thanks to the fading light of their artificial sun, none of the others had noticed yet; the herd was still a ways off.

Ivan stood at the edge of their makeshift campground, watching the waves of emerald as the forest betrayed its hidden forces. Most of the camp was gathered around the fire, trying to ignore the protests from their stomachs. There had been a few meager snacks collected, bags of peanuts and nutrition bars, that were being shared out among the kids as best they could. Little as it was, sometimes a single bite was enough to keep going. One step, one punch, it could all be the difference between death and survival.

Slipping away in that moment was possible. Legs like his covered ground at an incredible pace when pushed; getting there and back would be a minor matter. But the fight could take time, depending on how numerous and slippery the forces, long enough for him to be missed. That in itself wasn't so bad, but if anyone got the idea to mount an expedition, they'd be putting themselves and the children in serious peril.

Waiting was another option; it wouldn't be too long before the young ones got sleepy. Taking a guard shift, and then killing every threat in the area had been Ivan's original plan, and it was one that still had viability. Unfortunately, with no threats seen, Trey would go wandering off into the woods the next morning, dying almost as soon as he left the safety of their area.

Ivan had no particular care for the man, nor had he any distaste, but it didn't matter. They were at a Starscout function, Trey was one of them, and most of all, Ivan knew what Helen would say about the matter. He couldn't let the man die needlessly for no reason, but he also couldn't risk letting a horde of monsters near these children.

This was why villainy was so much easier than cape-work—fewer variables to consider. When all one had was a target, it simplified things greatly. Less to keep track of, such as fellow Starscout leaders. Ivan heard the crunch of dry grass before either of them spoke, already turning toward Trey and Yuri.

“While the kids are distracted, I thought we should have a little huddle,” Yuri suggested, tossing frequent looks over her shoulder to the circle of children. “Ivan, I raised your points to Trey, but we're both still in agreement. With no threats present, it makes more sense to send him on to help the others.”

“I understand there might be dangers further out there, I do.” Trey stepped forward, set on making this declaration himself. “But we can't do nothing while supplies run out. I have to go try.”

Perhaps it was the people that made villain-work easier, Ivan reconsidered. If these two had been a bit less responsible, they'd have happily sat around waiting for the problem to get solved. More cowardly, they wouldn't have had the guts to try to leave. Easily corruptible, and Ivan could have appealed to some lower urge for motivation. What the hell was he supposed to do with someone who was aware there was risk, but still determined to help?

With limited other options, Ivan decided it was time for some specific truth-telling. “We're past the point of ‘if’ there are dangers. Seeing as there's no wind, and I don't feel the ground shaking, there aren't many other explanations for that.” Pointing out toward the growing darkness, Ivan drew their attention to the waving trees.

“What? It's just forest.” Yuri had cupped her hands to her eyes, trying to block out as much light as possible from the fire.

“Give it time, let your eyes adjust.” While Ivan's gaze had needed no such shift, he felt reasonably sure a normal human could still catch enough details to notice the movement.

It was Trey who saw it first, the sharp intake of air almost slipping back out as an unintended hiss. “That can't be creatures.”

“Why not?” Ivan asked.

“Because if it is, then we’re all dead. That much force, shaking trees that big, it would roll over this area like a wave.” Trey’s eyes were haunted, and Ivan suddenly wondered if perhaps this wasn’t his first meta-adventure.

Here, Ivan found himself at a crossroads. He could, in theory, continue revealing small patches of truth. The easiest route would be to admit he was a meta-human without giving away any actual details. A small display of his warding power would likely convince the pair he was keeping all the threats at bay, and continuing to sneak away easily became sellable as him reinforcing the magic. Unfortunately, that still required admitting that he was more than human, and Ivan’s identity was heavily founded on being boring and unremarkable.

The other option was to explain as little as possible, keep them guessing, and hope Helen was making good time. Riskier in the long-term, but if Ivan could shuffle through this without an overt power display, the rest would fade away in their minds. Between the fear, stress, and adrenaline, no one would have solid recall of this, nor would they especially want it.

At least, that’s what Ivan was banking on.

“There is another possibility. When Beth and I were in the woods earlier, I caught sight of a strange stone carving a ways off. It may have been glowing, though at the time, I dismissed it as a trick of the light. It was too far to investigate in the moment, but now, I’m thinking it might be essential.”

“What does some rock matter in the face of that?” Trey asked, still gazing at the fidgeting forest.

“Maybe nothing, but we’re in a place with unnatural rules. I had the notion that perhaps the reason we’ve been safe here is that there’s something special about this spot. A barrier of some sort. It’s the only explanation I can think of for why there would enough monsters to do *that*, yet they still haven’t come for the camp.”

The gasp from Yuri confirmed she’d managed to spot the movement as well, bringing all three adults largely on board with the knowledge they were facing a threat. Lowering her hands, she took a long breath, gripping onto her own forearms. It was a trick Ivan knew well from his younger days, a way to keep one’s hands from visibly shaking. He was glad they



were both smart enough to be scared—dealing with idiots would have made the task even harder.

“I’m going to go investigate that stone, see what the glow was, and if there are others. Hopefully, I’ll find some sort of clue, or at least confirm that my eyes weren’t playing tricks.”

“I’ll come, too,” Trey said, moving to Ivan’s side. He was halted, immediately, by a surprisingly strong hand on his chest.

Careful to make no expression, Ivan shook his head. “No. If I’m wrong, then I’m walking into danger. Better one dies, than two. The kids still need us.”

For a flicker of a moment, Trey faltered, the weight of the situation fully settling in. Then, he tried to step forward once more, despite Ivan’s hand. “Then *I* should be the one to go. Your daughter is right over there.”

“That would make sense, if you were the one who’d seen the stone’s location.” Or if any such rock existed in the first place. “Better I go swiftly than you bumble around in the dark. And while the sentiment is appreciated, Beth being here is why I’m the one who goes. I have more reason than anyone to fight my way back.”

He turned away, deciding it was better to simply leave and trust them not to follow at this point. That wave of movement was drawing steadily closer, and might take some time to get through. Ivan was ready to show these peons of the jungle what a true apex predator was.



The root snagged Tori’s foot, sending her sailing forward, face directly on a crash course with a nearby tree trunk. Hands snapped onto her shoulders, steadying her just before impact, as Helen gently helped her back to a standing position.

“That’s it, we’re stopping to rest.”

Even as she verbally protested, Tori’s body enthusiastically wanted to agree. Between the mediocre breakfast, abduction of the cluster, and heavy amount of activity, she was beginning to feel the drain. Hunger nagged at her belly, the first itch of true thirst was taking hold, and her muscles ached to take a rest. Most of her Hephaestus work happened in short spurts; it wasn’t often she needed to take a marathon approach.

“We don’t have time to stop. Everyone is counting on us.” At Tori’s words, Helen’s whole face twitched, though what that meant was entirely up to speculation.

There was a brief pause, then Helen found her voice once more. “Everyone is counting on us, which is why we have to stop. Blazing through recklessly could get us hurt, or worse, and if we fail, then what? Ivan has to actually leave the scouts, or drag them along through whatever dangers are still to come. It’s late, you’re tired, and even using your power to turn sticks into torches, it’s getting hard to see. Right now, you’re more burden than asset.”

The last bit especially stung, since Tori could hardly deny it. She was slowing them down; she was the one Helen had to catch. If they were in a fight, Tori could easily make some careless mistakes in a state like this. Yet every part of her screamed to keep going, keep working, stay ahead of everything.

In the end, Tori decided to split the difference. She needed to rest, but for how long was still open to discussion. A brief respite to recover, and they could get back at it. Nodding in agreement, Tori stepped out of Helen’s grip, motioning to an open section of woods not far away. “Want me to build us a fire?”

“We’ve got nothing to cook and no chill to ward off, but I do love the sound of a nice crackle, so I won’t fight you on it. Just sit tight while I grab the kindling.”

Moving slowly, eyes watching the ground for further obstacles, Tori wandered over to the minor clearing, which was more a break in the canopy than anything. Once settled, she extinguished what remained of her current torch, a random stick picked up when the last one burned down. Helen had no issues seeing in the dark, her excellent eyes further proving that the glasses were truly cosmetic.

Within a few minutes, Helen had returned, arms filled with various twigs and sticks. Dropping the whole load down in front of Tori, Helen wandered over to a tree and pressed her back against it, finding a semi-lean that in no way appeared comfortable.

One bit of focus, and the fire caught, rippling through the kindling in no time to create a bright, vibrant blaze. It was strangely comforting, even without actual purpose. The monsters wouldn’t care, and Helen was right

about food and temperature. Still, looking into the flames relaxed Tori, earning a cry of joy from her back as tension slowly faded.

“Resting might not have been the worst idea.”

“With age comes wisdom, and that includes the importance of taking breaks.”

Tori looked the woman over for the umpteenth time that day, ever since her power had been revealed. “Seeing as you only look a few years older than me, I’m guessing part of that perfect-body package is slower aging?”

“That’s definitely one way to look at it,” Helen replied. “Without bogging down in details, let’s just say I wear my years exceptionally well.”

“You and Ivan both. I have to get me some of those anti-aging powers before it’s too late. Last thing I need is dementia or arthritis setting in.” Tori said it as a joke, yet as the words left her mouth, she wondered... was that on the table? She’d never dug into all the resources the guild offered, focusing on things directly related to her and her goals. Having more time to be young and full of energy sure wouldn’t hurt, though.

“They aren’t always as great as you might think, but it’s case by case.” Helen’s gaze drifted into the fire, her focus shifting for a brief, unmistakable moment. “Besides, as I see it, you’ve got quite a useful ability already. Form-phasing, heat control, long-range attacks, flight, and that’s just what you’ve shown so far. If I didn’t know better, I might think I was hanging out with a superhero.”

The strange notion tickled Tori to imagine, purely for its ridiculousness. “Yeah, that was obviously never on the table for me.”

Helen’s face grew unexpectedly serious. “With all due respect, that’s not true. Anyone can choose to protect the innocent, to fight for those who can’t fight for themselves. Not all on the same scale, and not all in the same way, but every sentient creature has the potential to help. To use whatever strengths they have and make the world better.”

A strange place for a conversational dig-in, though not entirely shocking. People had strong opinions on capes; often, they’d been saved by one. Even without that personal connection, every person alive had to live with the knowledge that the world only still existed because capes had successfully defended it multiple times. Granted, the threats were usually meta-human or created by said capes, so there was a chicken-and-the-egg question to be asked, but the fact remained that the Earth was still spinning.

“I guess I could have phrased that better. What I meant is that it was never really on the table because I don’t have that instinct. If I see things going sideways, my first thought is how to get out safely. After that, I think about how much of the shit I care about can come along, too.”

The fire crackled between them. Tori could feel Helen’s eyes on her, more focused than ever before. The attention was unexpectedly heavy, and oddly familiar in a way her brain just *refused* to place.

“Is that really how you see yourself, Tori? A selfish coward?”

“I’m a scientist first and foremost. We go by observable data. Historically speaking, that’s how I act, so it’s the conclusion I draw.”

“Sounds to me like you’ve got a lot of bias in your data collection,” Helen countered. “Because my observations have been quite different. I’ve seen a woman stick by a someone she thought would be nothing more than a burden to drag around. I’ve watched you show concern for people in danger over yourself, both in theory and in practice. Heck, let’s take it from you directly. When I said we should stop a few minutes ago, what did you come back with?”

Tori jumped back in her mind, trying to replay things. “I said there wasn’t enough time to stop.”

“Close. You said there wasn’t time, because everyone is counting on us.” This time, there was nothing subtle about the knowing grin on Helen’s face. “I’ve met and known a lot of capes through the years—more than I think you’d believe. ‘Everyone is counting on us.’ *That* sure sounds like something a superhero would say.”

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## Chapter 83

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“Professor Quantum?”

The aide waved, trying to flag him down. Persistent fellow. Most gave up after being ignored the first several times. That meant the matter must be important, at least in the aide’s mind. Relenting his constant pace, Professor Quantum turned to the red-faced man waving a document.

“Yes?”

“Sorry to bother you, sir. We’ve been trying to reach out by phone, but there seems to be an issue.” The issue was that Professor Quantum had been ignoring the missives, a fact that both knew and neither would say. “Got a report that came in, flagged high priority. Some kind of orb thing appeared over a Starscout retreat and people are missing. Looks like a Cobblord piece.”

At the sound of an older enemy, Professor Quantum allowed his interest to raise its head. He snatched the document from the aide’s hand. “Seems as though there’s several layers of warped time folded around it, which means breaking through will be quite difficult—as well as unnecessary. We shouldn’t get involved.”

“Beg pardon?” The aide looked sure that they’d misheard.

Professor Quantum tossed the page back over, paying no attention to if it was caught. “Lodestar has expressed her desire for the Starscouts to be an entity separate from the AHC many times. Since she’s so set on that distinction, we wouldn’t want to step on toes and go rushing in. I saw that Quorum has already been dispatched, and we all know Lodestar keeps a

special eye on that organization. I have no doubt the issue will be handily resolved.”

The aide hung in the hallway, staring with mouth agape. To him, it probably seemed as if Professor Quantum were being hard-hearted, but the truth was much simpler. As any enterprise, the Alliance of Heroic Champions had limited resources. There were only so many capes on duty or reachable at any given time, and from that pool, they had to be able to deal with any major threat to the world’s safety at often minimal notice.

Considering all that, Professor Quantum could think of few greater wastes of resources than sending reinforcements to Lodestar. Not that the aide had any way of knowing she was there, thanks to that ridiculous secret identity. Truly, the only thing Professor Quantum held in higher esteem than Lodestar’s power was Helen’s capacity to utterly waste it.



To tell the tale of Fornax was to sing a song of blood. Blood from Ivan, dripping off cuts in his knuckles, running down his chin, pooling in his ears. Blood from the others, felled one at a time by each other’s hands. Blood from his captors, taken in their moment of triumph. Blood from their allies, from every member of their cult, every soul connected to the horror of Fornax’s creation. So much blood there were days he’d wondered if his eyes had been stained, if he could ever see the world in terms other than flesh to be torn apart.

These creatures had no blood. Ivan drove a fist through the skull-shaped rock of a horned beast the size of a commuter bus, obliterating the head along with the entirety of its body, rocks spraying across the rest of the herd. No blood was a blessing. It made cleanup all the easier. More than that, though, it helped Ivan keep control. The darkness was always there, always pressing to be let out. Whispering that this is who he truly was, where he rightly belonged. Tempting him to go wilder, to enjoy himself. Reminding him of the only thing he’d ever felt made for.

Destruction.

If the trees were painted in viscera, it would have stirred those old memories harder, feeding his worst impulses. This was better, cleaner on multiple levels.

Ivan smashed through the other two giant horned beasts, then shoved past their rubble. He'd been picking off the advance troops as he approached, but staring down the slope he'd reached, Ivan realized that his trek was nearly done. What he was looking at had to be the main force, based on the way the entire forest rippled with their steps. A mishmash of shapes, some animalistic, some humanoid, some truly a design entirely unto themselves. The details didn't matter to Ivan. It was all the same. Rocks to be shattered, enemies to be broken.

This was nothing. Sliding down the dry grass, Ivan leapt into the air, coming down on the back of a horse-sized stone monster covered in spikes. It burst into pieces as his limbs made contact, a wave of power washing out from where Ivan hit the ground, cracking several nearby opponents. Ivan had never cared much for wielding widespread magic, even if his fighting was inherently suited to it. He preferred a one-on-one match, or at least to take down each enemy with his own fists. Tonight wasn't about his preferences, however. It was about keeping that camp protected.

Not even caring what his hand landed upon, Ivan grabbed the nearest stone limb and swung it around, turning the creature into a club he used to bludgeon the first movement that caught his eye. Down here, surrounded by chaos, Ivan's mind couldn't help flashing back to the pit.

Everything was a fight: food, water, a place to sleep. Their captors' favorite method had been to turn everyone loose in the pit, and then allow the winner first choice of their prize while the others were left with scraps. When Ivan showed a bit of talent early on, he inadvertently made himself a target. For years, they would come at him together, making him alone even in a place meant to drive all to isolation.

The limb crumbled in Ivan's tightened grip. He barely even registered the loss, dashing forward, deeper into the thick of combat. He grabbed a pair of gorilla-sized stone monsters by the heads, decapitating both. Multiple opponents meant nothing to him; that was the benefit of surviving all those group attacks. Without meaning to, the others had made him even stronger. By the time the numbers thinned, Ivan had already been winning fights against them collectively. One-on-one... well, there was a reason he was still alive, and they weren't.

Ivan came to a stop, realizing that, without noticing, he'd torn through a bunch of stone spheres held aloft by spider-like limbs. Whatever unexpected function they'd had was lost; their rubble revealed no secrets.

Pausing, Ivan forced himself to breathe, mentally getting out of the pit. It was dangerous to lose himself in the past, even for a moment. He couldn't give in, couldn't let that piece of him escape.

Something huge moved in Ivan's periphery. Not quite a stone dinosaur, but the sizes of these things were starting to get ridiculous. It had only been one day, why was the labyrinth pushing so hard on the second wave?

Hesitantly, Ivan felt more power flow into his fists. Releasing condensed waves of pure obliteration magic on every hit would cut down his time, but he loathed using the technique like this. The more destructive Ivan became, the deeper he verged into Fornax's territory. There was a reason that name had stuck, coined as it was for a black hole. In his early days, before he learned better control, Fornax truly was a walking disaster—collateral damage was almost a feature of his abilities. Ivan had already spent a lifetime fighting to win at all costs; paired with the sudden increase in raw strength, he'd barely been able to throw a jab without creating a corpse.

This power was meant to destroy. Always had been, since before it was Ivan's to wield. He'd met its source, overcome that endless appetite to unmake the world with his own will for survival. But putting his burden on a leash didn't change its nature. As Ivan stepped forward, moving toward his giant target, a stone quadruped with long, lashing limbs bounded toward him. A single blow not only shattered his opponent, it sent the shards flying like shrapnel, tearing chunks off the other nearby enemies. Ivan repeated the trick on the next one he could reach, then another, all while moving toward the big beast. It had been a while since he used this technique—a few calibration shots always helped.

The head of this enemy was massive—easily the size of the horned beasts he'd slain not too far back. As for the rest of it, Ivan could see a long stone neck leading to a body he imagined would be covered in thick armor, spines, maybe even some surprise defenses meant to shake off anyone who climbed on board. With his higher vantage point, Ivan opted not to mess with the head. Probably a fake target. The body would be where the real vulnerabilities lay. Cobblord was no rank amateur; he knew how to build a decent monster.

Decent by most people's standards, anyway. To Ivan, these were all the same. The same as those frail cultists whose bones were so easily torn out. The same as so many big-talking opponents who'd raised his hopes only to



break after a single blow. The same as the countless challengers who paled in horror upon realizing the fight they'd picked. The same as every piece of fodder these unstoppable fists had effortlessly crushed... until the shining one who was different. Until the punch that was stopped, and everything else that unexpected moment had started.

"Cobblord, I don't know if you can hear me, or if you're monitoring any of this. But just in case, I wanted to pass along a message: you should have let them kill you." Ivan leapt over the head of the monster, toward the main body. All around it, he could see smaller stone forms, the army circling its strongest asset. How convenient of them all to group together for him.

Landing on its back, Ivan reared back, ready to throw a full-strength punch before thinking better of it. That might crack the entire mechanism of the orb, tripping Cobblord's fiercest defenses, if not a full collapse of their prison. Holding back, Ivan thrust his arm into the nearest patch of stone he saw. The initial hit left a crater, but it was the aftereffect that truly got the show started. Just like the earlier monsters, charged flecks of stone went flying off as shrapnel. Except, thanks to the opponent's greater size, these shards were fist-sized at their smallest, tearing through his massive enemy's inner workings as much as through the peons on the ground.

"Whoever it was, whatever threats they made to get you on board, you should have let them kill you. Because I don't give a shit how much you knew about their plans for this. I'm going to find you. And when I do, I'll show you the folly of your ways. You should have let them kill you, Cobblord. It would have been an easier death than the one I'll bring."

Ivan truly had no idea if Cobblord could watch the happenings of his creations, or if the threat had merely been for his unthinking audience. It was mostly habit, either way. Terrifying an opponent was often an easier way to win than bothering to make a fist. Besides, when it came to both Ivan and Fornax, the words were never really the message.

Explosions of energy tore through the giant monster as Ivan struck again, this time leaving his hand wedged inside. Rocks burst forth, shooting into the nearby hordes and blowing them into rubble. As he stood there atop his giant prey, watching the sea of enemies fall against his power, Ivan tried very, very hard to remember that this was purely a defensive necessity. Otherwise, an especially mad part of him would take too much joy in the spectacle.

Destruction spread like a spiderweb as Ivan rained down more blows, triggering blast after blast. A maelstrom of violence, a parade of obliteration. Like the black hole his other name was stolen from, Ivan wiped out his enemies, the forest, and everything in the surrounding areas. There was no distinction between them; they were all simply objects to be broken.

He wouldn't let one of these things slip past, couldn't risk the life of single scout. Ivan would never be like Lodestar—his powers didn't function the same way. If he had to fight with others around, it put them in danger. Acting before the threat arrived, preemptive annihilation, that was the only real tactic that worked for him. Ivan would be just as meticulous, thorough, and patient as he was at the office. One by one, until the last movement halted, he would crush this army.

So much of his life was about hiding who he was and what he could really do. For tonight, a brief and beautiful moment, Ivan felt united. His better self was determined to protect those kids, whereas his darker impulses were gleeful at the chance to rampage. Everything in him agreed that the only course of action was to wipe these bastards out.

Raising a fist overhead, Ivan felt a mad grin try to wiggle its way onto his face, an impulse he immediately squashed down. This was not Fornax running wild: this was Ivan Gerhardt sending a very clear, explosive message about what happened to anyone who threatened his family.

He hoped Cobblord *was* watching somewhere. Ivan wanted him afraid, wanted him cowering. The reputation of Fornax was one of the few things that kept his family safe. A little wanton decimation here and there was a nice way to remind people why they should be so afraid. Of course, in all likelihood, Cobblord probably wasn't watching. There was so much to keep track of, even if he had surveillance. That was fine, too, though.

When it was all over, Ivan would be sure to hunt him down and explain the error of his ways in person. For as long as Cobblord could endure.

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## Chapter 84

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In spite of her steadily weakening state—a quite natural reaction to extended effort with no nourishment or water—Tori insisted they press on, taking rest only when she had to in the form of a few catnaps, grabbed under the starlight and Helen’s watchful eye. At least Tori was accustomed to keeping late hours; it meant they didn’t have to worry about drowsiness becoming a factor just yet.

Helen was taking no chances, though. Raising a child through toddlerhood had taught her the power of persistent gab, especially letting loose questions and refusing to be ignored. She wasn’t quite as bad as Penelope in her prime, but Helen could force a conversation to stay afloat when needed, especially if it meant keeping someone mentally active. Having Tori out this far into the labyrinth was dangerous enough. If she started making poor judgment calls, it could lead to injury or worse. That wasn’t going to happen. Helen would make sure it didn’t. This was simply the easiest method of doing so, for the time being.

“—and then he lets his friend go, watching him paddle off into the fifty-year storm, knowing he probably won’t come back. Throws his badge into the waves as he fades from sight. Seriously, you have to look this one up when we get out of here. True classic. It got me into surfing for a solid five-year stint.”

“I’ll add it to the list,” Tori replied, tone and words both a bit stiff. Helen had been going hard on Multerion movies for the last hour, veering between ones Tori knew about and far more varied fare. While the topic had

started out promising, based on that reaction, it was probably time to switch things up. The chatter wasn't as effective unless it flowed in both directions.

Well... if she wanted to make sure Tori's brain was active and aware, there was a topic she could skirt around that was sure to raise the woman's hackles. It felt a tad like cheating, using her Lodestar knowledge as Helen, but with careful wording, she saw a way forward.

"Let me know how you like it. I've nagged my coworkers enough that I doubt they'll ever give it a real shot. Oh, hey, speaking of coworkers, did you happen to know a man named Donald Moss? The superhero called Cyber Geek?" Conversational subtlety was not a skill Helen particularly cared about utilizing, unless it was absolutely necessary. Sometimes boldness was more effective, anyway.

Like a jolt, Tori's entire body straightened. She really needed to work on that. Had Helen not already known the full story, it would have been a deeply suspicious reaction. Slowly, Tori turned, a forced calm on her face that probably would have been more convincing if she'd had a touch more energy to spare toward acting. "What brought that to mind?"

"Coworkers, sort of," Helen explained. "I know Ivan used to manage him, prior to the career change, so I thought you two might have been acquainted. Had to ask—I mean, how many people know an actual superhero?"

"At this point, I know too many." Tori seemed surprised by her own slip of the tongue, hastily recovering as best she could. "After my kidnapping, I got a protective detail put around me, met a few of the capes doing the work. But yeah, I know Donald, too. He was a friend before his change, and we tried to keep that alive afterward."

"Tried?" That was news to Helen, and Cyber Geek wasn't the stoic sort. If a friendship had broken, he'd likely have worn some visible reaction around the base.

Shoving her way through a dense patch of undergrowth, Tori spared a few moments to form a rough shrug. "Not like we had a big cursing fight and vowed to stop being buds... lately I've been realizing more and more that our lives are heading in different directions. Cyber Geek is going to be a big name one day, and I'll still cheer for him from the sidelines. Just not sure how much longer our worlds will overlap."

To Helen, the hardest feat in the universe was to see someone hurting, be able to help, and simply not. Fornax's life was built upon blood, but

Lodestar's foundation was one of loss. Too many times, she'd been unable to help. Too many failures, funerals, tears, and screams. It was what made her the Lodestar she was, and even without her powers in play, that instinct didn't fade. She knew what Tori was saying, *really* saying. A villain and a superhero couldn't be friends. It was a ludicrous notion—to someone in Tori's position.

"If you'll forgive an intrusion from someone who doesn't know you all that well yet, don't be so quick to give up. Life takes strange turns for everyone, sometimes doubling back in directions you'd never imagine. Whether you have overlap or not is a passing occurrence. A good friend, one you trust, who trusts you, and who you want in your life? That's not something to throw away lightly. Even if the circumstances around you change, so long as you value one another, it is possible for a bond to endure."

"Okay, seriously, how old *are* you?" Tori suddenly demanded. "That sounded like someone with a lot more experience than your face shows, even considering the slow aging."

"Old enough to spot a change of topic when I see one." Helen ducked under a branch, not actually bothered by the question. Tori was more engaged than she'd been during the movie talk, which meant she was also more alert. That was the victory Helen had been after in the first place. "Sorry, I don't think I'm especially vain, but I'm still not giving out my age. A gal's allowed a few secrets."

Together, the pair broke through a tree line, only to spot a slight downward slope leading to more forest. There was a path they were following, choppy and thin as it could be at times. Where it was leading, and what would be waiting for them along the way, were mysteries yet to be discovered.

As artificial dawn rose overhead, light returned, making navigation easier, if not faster. Were Ivan running through this place, he'd have blown past them. Then again, he'd also have been forced to leave the kids. Slow, steady, and safe won the day for Helen over brash and reckless. She'd had too many chances to learn better.

"It's not like I want to kick friends out of my life. I've never... I haven't had the chance for many, the way my life has broken. Losing one, even by my own hand, sucks. But it's probably best, in the long run."

Safer, was what Tori really meant. Safer for Hephaestus, less chances to expose a secret. Safer for Cyber Geek, should her secret ever come out and their friendship turn into an anchor around his heels. Safer for Donald and Tori, because the stronger a friendship grew, the more it hurt when the long-buried truths finally came out.

Helen didn't just know this story, she was *exhausted* of it.

"Who you love, trust, and let into your life is ultimately something only you can decide. *But* if you reject anyone who might cause things to get complicated or gums up whatever future roadmap you had in mind, it's going to be a very lonely life to live. That's a steep slope, deciding things are broken before they even have a chance to be tested."

"It's better to leave yourself vulnerable?" Tori was starting to get worked up, which was good for her energy levels, though not so great for keeping her focused. "You might have meta-human aging, but you've got no idea the kind of shit I've seen. I spent years hunkered in holes and hiding in shadows. I've seen plenty of what happens to those so free with their trust. Usually, it ends with them bleeding and screaming, if they're lucky enough to still be alive."

Helen's heart broke as she looked at the fury and pain in Tori's eyes. Though the young villain could have no way of knowing it, Helen had indeed witnessed those sights. When she was new, not yet fully using her abilities, it had been more frequent, but even now, there were times she was too late. Lodestar, for all her power, was still a single person. Even at her fastest, she couldn't be everywhere. She couldn't stop every crime, save every innocent—no matter how much the failures weighed upon her.

"Being vulnerable isn't easy," Helen agreed. "It's why choosing who you trust is such a vital part of the process. But no matter how careful you are, mistakes will happen. Hurts, slights, maybe even betrayals. Nobody's perfect, as a person or a friend. Knowing when to forgive, and how, is a vital part of making those relationships work. Because people can surprise you in good ways, too. You never really know what someone is capable of, who they are, all the way through. People can amaze and astound when given the chance."

"I'm sure that's good advice in a general sense, but this is more complicated than hearing Ivan bust a tune. For my situation, this is what's best for all involved. I think it's the way it has to be."

Through no fault of Tori's, those final words made Helen's jaw clench. She'd heard that phrase many a time in the early days, before she got comfortable in her role as a leader. "I don't believe anything has to be a certain way. This is our world, built by the hands and desires of those who came before us. Now, it's our turn. Whatever you see out there that you don't like: change it. Who creates society if not the people in it? Who shapes this world if not its residents? This is your life, Tori. Your slice of existence. Who do you think has more control over it than you?"

"It's not like I—" Tori was cut off by the long stone spike that shot up from the ground, narrowly missing her left foot. It rose ten feet into the air before stopping completely, reorienting, and slicing down toward Tori yet again. She dodged easily. With so much time to prepare, it was an easy move to make. The stone carved through the dirt, vanishing into the ground. Where it had burrowed, only a small mound remained.

Together, the pair looked ahead at the long stretch of grass and the countless small dirt mounds they were only now paying attention to. If each one represented a similar trap, they might be able to walk through without stepping directly on one. However, Helen hadn't noticed a mound when Tori triggered the first. It was possible those merely represented entry points. The stone spikes were obviously able to navigate this place's underground.

Meaning that any step could trigger an attack.

Eyeing the tree branches, Helen flexed her fingers. It had been a while since she needed to go hopping around. She'd never even heard the term parkour back when Helen was leaping building gaps and free-climbing old brick exteriors. Luckily, being Lodestar meant never getting rusty. With a running start, Helen hopped up, kicking off the nearest trunk, grabbing onto a thick branch before pulling to a squat. She could already see her next two jumps. After that, things would have to get more fluid and improvisational.

"Tori, you okay to fly?"

"Little worn out, but I can manage." As proof, Tori was already halfway into fire form, having read the situation for herself. Helen couldn't help noticing that the change was taking longer this time. Exhaustion was on Tori's heels. Sooner or later, it would catch her.

But not yet. Tori's hands formed fists before vanishing into pure flames, her whole body blazing as she lifted into the sky, careful to go high enough

to avoid the treetops. Slow and steady was the way to go. They'd get through this one hurdle at a time.

Unfortunately, just as Helen watched Tori crest over the trees, the blast came. It was pure wind, from the looks of things. That was a new attack, which meant they were probably near the site of the next trial. It had been waiting in the air, so this whole area was meant to be a trap, no matter the route they picked. Given how Ivan favored his leaping techniques, preparing for aerial entry was smart, but it also meant the force was strong enough to theoretically knock an airborne Fornax off-balance. Since Tori's mass was lightened for flight, and she hadn't been prepared to counterblast, the attack shot her forward, well past their current section of forest and toward unknown threats.

Plans of slow and safe movement fell away as Helen accepted what she'd just seen. While she knew Tori to be capable, the younger woman was also running on fumes in a trap made with Fornax in mind. Whatever plans this place had for her were about to be dashed, however. Even if Ivan hadn't asked Helen to watch over her, this wouldn't stand. Tori wasn't here as Hephaestus. She'd come as a normal civilian helping to plan a weekend. Even if that hadn't been enough, she was part of Helen's cluster, and Lodestar's organization.

An innocent civilian was in peril, and Helen was close enough to see it. There was only one way that scenario could end. This was how *she* chose to shape the world—into a place where every cry for help carried with it the genuine hope and knowledge that somewhere out there, at least one person cared. For now, she ran, dropping off her perch and dodging the spikes as they leapt from ground. Hopefully, Helen could make it in time.

But if she couldn't, then Lodestar would.



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## Chapter 85

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It was some kind of vortex, near as Tori could figure. More than just wind, there were small objects being tossed about with her—small bladed ones, from the looks she could snag. Against a normal flying or jumping opponent caught in the wind, these would be a flurry of wounds slicing into one's skin, a constant, unstoppable assault from all angles. Pitted against an intangible target, they were a minor distraction to steal her attention and complicate the process of descent.

The blast had shot her across the forest, above some massive stone circle that seemed to be generating the wind and the blades. That didn't particularly explain how it was shooting wind toward itself. Her hunch was hidden remote stations that were used to create the effect—but being bounced around the sky made it tough to discern precise locations. She had to get low, there was no other choice, but she couldn't manage a clean shot out of the vortex. As carefully as possible, Tori began to solidify parts of herself in bursts, temporarily increasing her weight. The wind could blow all it wanted, gravity always pulled in one direction.

Unfortunately, turning solid even in pieces left her vulnerable. A rogue blade caught her on a solidified shin, while another tore a piece from her shoulder. Nevertheless, Tori was making progress, slowly falling out of the wind's grasp toward the waiting ground below. As she fell, she took a better look at the surroundings.

The forest ended a short way back, leaving only plains of fake grass leading up to the stone circle. Now that she was closer, Tori could see that it was actually several rings laid together, like someone had chopped a section

out of a ridiculously oversized rock-redwood. The wind and blades seemed to be drifting up from the cracks between sections—hopefully, this whole thing was just one giant wind generator. Except this place was made with Fornax in mind, and while he did have the ability to fight and travel through the air, this sort of trap would be little more than an annoyance. Then again, wasn't that the point of this entire labyrinth? Even the voice they'd heard hadn't expected it to actually stop him—the whole thing was about sending a message.

Suddenly, the world turned more peaceful as Tori fell out of the wind's grasp. She was below the swirling mass of air, only a few feet from the ground, and the moment was almost serene. Had she been better rested and fed, Tori's sharp mind might have realized how precious such a place was and paused there momentarily before risking any additional movement. Sadly, the toll of her efforts was making itself known, and Tori dropped heavily to the ground, shifting back to human form as she took a dearly needed rest.

No sooner had her feet touched the ground than the noise started, of course. The grinding of stone was like a loud buzzer blaring at the sound of her mistake. In the air, she'd been caught up by happenstance. Landing had obviously tripped some sort of sensor, and having mass when she came down probably didn't help. Part of Tori was glad that Helen had been left further back, even as she wished there was someone else around the help. Limited as that powerset was in terms of scale, Helen had proven adept with it. Still, this would be easier without having to worry about a semi-normal person to keep track of.

That was Tori's thought until she saw the first huge stone leg rise from a rising section of the outermost ring. Ten feet long, with a square, unbalanced body following, along with four more multi-jointed legs. Worse, there wasn't a scrap of greenery she could see on it, meaning that there would be little to burn. Way worse were the dozen other legs she saw exiting from around the ring. The last test had been designed to pit Fornax against one massive opponent. This time, it seemed one had to survive being overrun by what would be small fries to someone on his scale. With her suit, Tori felt she could have made a serious go of surviving this. Given her current condition, even escape would take some lucky breaks.

Rustling from behind her had Tori whipping around, fireballs already formed in her hand; however, there was no stealth force approaching from

the rear. Instead, she found the dashing form of Helen, who'd sprinted out from the tree line and was racing over. Tori's heart fell to her stomach. This was too dangerous for the kind-hearted cluster leader. Even if Ivan hadn't screamed his request across the sky, she liked Helen. Tori didn't want to see her hurt, or worse, which was looking increasingly likely as more and more crawling cubes came up out of the ground. And that was only the first ring—there were still eight more to go.

"What are you doing?" Tori demanded as soon as Helen made it into earshot range. "Get the fuck out of here! Can you not see those things pouring out?"

The words appeared to catch Helen momentarily off guard, after which she reacted quite oddly. A warm smile was not what one expected in this kind of situation. "Tori, are you trying to put yourself between me and the danger?"

"I'm trying to do what Ivan asked and keep you safe," Tori snapped, eyes darting over to the advancing stone troops. "Go around this area. I'll handle it, but I need time. While I deal with these punks, you sneak ahead and try to find whatever mechanism will end all this. I might not even have to scrap all of them."

It was bullshit, pure and simple. These things would overrun Tori in no time, and with the skies turned chaotic, she couldn't snipe from the air, whatever good that would have done. At best, her fire form would protect her from their attacks, and she could keep them distracted enough for Helen to get away. The woman was shockingly capable. Maybe she actually would activate the exit before Tori's stamina ran out. It was the best chance for everyone, including Ivan and Beth. Tori would figure out a way to survive somehow—it's what she did. That's what she told herself, anyway.

"You want to go charging into an army you've got no way to damage, just because of what Ivan said?" Helen was somehow unaffected by the advancing forces, the entirety of her focus still on Tori.

"Look, lady, this really isn't the time for a deep-dive into my shit. It's been a long, hard, dangerous life. Ivan is the first person in very long while to genuinely give a fuck about me. He's helped me in ways I don't know how to repay. I'm not letting his friend die while I've still got fight left in these bones." Summoning flames in each hand, Tori turned back to the cubes, drawing steadily closer. Not long left until they'd arrive. "So get out of here and let me get to work." It was an excellent performance, marred

only by a minor wobble in her voice at the very end. Given what she was staring down, Tori felt it forgivable that a sliver of fear had made itself known.

“Tori... I’m sorry.” Helen stepped to her side, entirely ignoring the directive to run. Something had changed, though. The light joy was gone. In its place was not terror at the nearing onslaught, but rather remorse. “I was selfish. It’s been a long time since I could talk with someone like this, a person who knows our world but not my place in it. I never meant for you to feel this kind of fear.”

Based on the speed of the advancing cubes on legs, they had less than a minute left, and that was being generous. As if that weren’t enough, there were more legs rising from the second stone ring, these even larger than the first design. “Helen, I don’t know what the hell you’re talking about, but if you’ve got a plan, now would be a great time to let me in on it.”

“Same plan as always, I suppose. Save the day.” Facing away from Tori, Helen carefully took off her glasses, folding the legs over one another. A ripple ran across her whole body, like an illusion shifting, except the changes Tori could see were minor, some slight shifts in weight and hair, with perhaps a small alteration in height. Still looking away, Helen continued to speak. “Time for *your* Starscout trivia challenge, Tori. Where does Lodestar’s name come from?”

The whole moment was deeply surreal, to the point where Tori was starting to wonder if she’d succumbed to fatigue and passed out without noticing. Dream or reality, her best bet was to play along. Perhaps it would do something about that damned mental itch Helen provoked, the one that was only growing stronger by the second.

“Corvix had just defeated Professor Quantum on national television. A bunch of other capes tried to swarm him, and he started cutting a swath like they were regular humans. Then, in a flash, she was there, putting herself in the path of his blows. He hit her with everything he had and couldn’t make so much as a dent. Before she dropped him in a single punch, and Quorum delivered the surprise finish, he asked her how she could be so strong, and Lodestar responded: ‘The darker the night, the brighter the stars.’”

“That’s the one.” Helen looked back, and Tori suddenly realized the shift was more dramatic than she’d noted from the back—it seemed as if several years had dropped away. “Do me a favor, hold these.” She extended the glasses, wiggling them slightly, until Tori took them in her grasp. “I’ll

let you in on two secrets, Tori. The first is that I kind of hated that saying for a long time. It was told to me a lot during a particularly dark time, and didn't quite deliver the hope it was meant to. All of which is to say that the line wasn't planned. It's just what popped out in the moment."

"In the moment?" Tori could almost see the line connecting these obvious, blazing dots, yet her brain refused to connect them, even when it felt like it was *right there*.

"That would be the other secret." Helen began to step forward, changing before Tori's eyes. "I hope you'll forgive minor theatrics. It's not often I get to do these reveals." Light poured out from Helen: blazing, brilliant, and instantly familiar. As her hair and eyes changed hue, Tori was truly struck by how little else shifted. Without the costume, the resemblance was even more uncanny. It was a strange combination of being thunderstruck with shock and also overwhelmed by a feeling she could only describe as "of course." It was like her brain breathed a sigh of relief at finally being able to see what, in hindsight, seemed crazy obvious from the start, followed shortly by the near mind-breaking implication of what this all meant.

Tori had just spent the better part of the day palling around with the strongest superhero on the fucking planet, and that was barely the tip of the iceberg. Thinking about the way Helen and Ivan were around each other, as compared to their other identities, indicated that their story went way deeper than she'd been led to believe. Her brain buzzed with fear about what secrets she might have accidentally let slip, but none could find solid purchase. Part of that was due to overall exhaustion, though it also helped to have far more immediate concerns to focus on. The first wave of cube enemies was drawing close.

Too bad for them, it wasn't Helen and Tori who were waiting to meet them. Instead, the first stone leg came down next to Lodestar, who remained unmoved as it settled down hard into the dirt. She stared the thing up and down, noting the others close on its heels.

"On the off chance there's any sentience in there, now would be the time to give up. All evidence points to you being automated, so if there's more, I'd really like to know before this gets rough."

In response, the cube whipped one of its legs around, slamming it down onto Lodestar's head. At the same time, several panels on its smooth surface opened up, various devices sliding out. What they were or did would remain unknown, however, as Lodestar returned the blow with one

of her own. A single punch obliterated her opponent, sending chunks of it screaming into the air, up and through even the vortex of wind.

“Cobblord should be glad I’m the one here, instead of Fornax,” Lodestar noted. “He’d be insulted at the idea that these things are a challenge.”

“You’re not?” Tori asked, really unsure of where the hell else to go with conversation at this point.

“I’m a superhero, which means a whole lot more responsibility in the way I use my abilities.” With a motion of her hand, Lodestar formed and flung a ball of energy that detonated on impact, utterly decimating the nearest six cubes that were advancing from Tori’s direction. “For me, this is a chance to let loose with no fear about anyone getting hurt. No civilians nearby to protect, no need to worry about injuring my opponent. All I have to do is fight, and I tend to fare pretty darn well on that front.”

Truly, that might have been the greatest understatement Tori had ever heard. There wasn’t time to comment on it, as Lodestar was already moving forward, heading for the ring where multi-segmented stone lizard-like creatures were rising up. “Stay there and rest. I won’t let anything get close. After all, my dear friend Ivan asked me to keep you safe.”

Watching Lodestar race off toward the waves of enemies rising off the ground, turning into a shining missile of destruction, Tori finally hit her limit. She half-collapsed to the ground, letting her body rest as her mind went wild, reconciling this new information with everything she already knew. It was a noble effort, but one that quickly gave way to enjoying the spectacle of Lodestar annihilating the stone army.

Sometimes, it was nice to just sit back and watch the destruction unfold.

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## Chapter 86

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It was early for visitors, which narrowed down the number of people potentially knocking on their door. Beverly was the only one up, with Tori at her scout thing and Chloe sleeping in. Everyone in her family tended to be early risers—whether it was genetic or ingrained barely mattered anymore. Whatever the cause, she beat the dawn on many a morning. Today’s sunrise had come and gone, at least, so odds were this wasn’t some bold robber about to make a hell of a bad choice.

Peering through the peephole—one could never be too careful—she was surprised to see Austin standing in the hallway. Given the early hour and his predilection for manners, she’d assumed if any of the New Science Sentries were going to pull such a move, it would be Ike. She opened the door quickly; Austin wouldn’t be here if he didn’t have good reason. Only after it was fully ajar did it occur to Beverly that perhaps she *was* the reason. If he’d learned Bahamut’s true identity, this could be the start of a very uncomfortable conversation.

Thankfully, Austin seemed his normal self, which was to say that he grew flustered at the appearance of Beverly. It was almost cute, how helpless he was at hiding even his most basic of feelings. At first, she’d taken the whole thing for an act, that he was putting on the “aw shucks” vibe to better sell his cape-image, especially considering whose name he was borrowing. Still, for all her hatred toward Professor Quantum, Beverly refused to be the same kind of bastard he was. She denied herself the easy out of judging someone for the circumstance of their birth rather than the quality of their character, and over time had realized that whatever else

Austin had going on, he wasn't putting on an act. Unfortunately, that left her with the obvious dilemma of his not-so-subtle crush. She'd thought getting to know one another would move him past it, or at least lower the awkwardness, but so far, he was proving oddly static in that regard.

After a few moments, Austin had regained his composure, or as much as he ever managed when talking directly to Beverly. "Good morning. Sorry for the early hour. I wasn't sure if calling or gently knocking would wake fewer people."

"A text would also have been fine." Her annoyance was fading to curiosity as Beverly studied Austin further. Shifting body language, eyes darting up and down the hall, there was definitely something off. He had a nervous energy different from the usual infatuation.

"Wish I could, but this was a little too important," Austin replied. "Please let Tori know her security is going to be reduced tonight. I just got a message. There's a big meeting at the AHC. Not sure what's going down, but they're calling in almost everyone. It won't just be us who are gone. There probably won't even be capes nearby if something happens. This is all private, of course. We're not advertising a few hours of weakened forces. Still, I didn't feel right leaving Tori unguarded without her knowing."

Two extremely different parts of Beverly lit up simultaneously. On one side, she was consumed by duty, flooded with worry of what might happen to her friend. However, there was more to Beverly than there had once been. Deep within her, the Bahamut piece of her mind couldn't help whispering that this was also opportunity. If she knew of a time when the capes would be compromised, it meant more dangerous guild jobs could be undertaken. Were Tori there at her side, the Bahamut voice might have been stronger, but concern for her friend ultimately triumphed over her budding villainy.

"Appreciate the heads up. I'll let her know as soon as she gets back from her Starscout thing."

"Any word on how that's going?" Austin was still checking the hallway. Whatever this meeting was about, it clearly had his nerves agitated.

"Didn't expect any. Cell reception outside of civilization isn't exactly renowned for reliability," Beverly explained. "Besides, I can wait until tonight to hear about the fun pinecones they spotted. Only so much interesting stuff can happen on a camping trip."





It was no surprise that Lodestar made short work of her opponents. That was, to Tori's estimation, the *only* part of this hour that wasn't some form of mind-liquefying shock. Helen was Lodestar. Helen, Ivan's good friend. Ivan, who was really Fornax, which Helen *definitely* knew. That whole concept was weird enough; when she factored in the times they seemed to be almost flirting... it was a lot.

Before she'd even realized it, the battle was done. Lodestar annihilated one final stone contraption—twenty feet tall with components of all the other types that had come from the rings—by dropping down from above and shattering it to rubble, before flying swiftly back toward Tori. Fast as she'd been, Lodestar never dipped into super-speed, even now avoiding tripping any of the labyrinth's safeguards.

Floating down to the grass, the glow didn't fade like Tori had expected. Lodestar wasn't hiding anymore. She was unashamedly herself. "From experience, I'm guessing that revelation knocked you somewhat sideways. Would you like to ask questions, or should I start by running down the greatest hits?"

While Tori certainly had questions to pose, she knew better than to pass up freely volunteered information. Asking on her own, she might inadvertently skip something vital. "How about you go first while I compose myself?"

"You mean think of follow-ups," Lodestar pointed out. "Told you, not my first time doing this. I don't mind, there's just no need to bother pretending."

To that, Tori merely nodded. She wasn't sure she trusted her own tongue at this particular moment.

Lodestar sat down, albeit in a peculiar way. She lifted each leg into the air, assuming a cross-legged position, before floating her whole body toward the ground. "The big one to get out of the way is no, you're not stupid, crazy, or wildly imperceptive. Now that you know the secret, it probably seems obvious in hindsight. I've never been great at hiding my identity. I try, but tend to slip up on details. To put it simply: you couldn't see the truth because I hadn't revealed it to you yet."

Now that she'd settled, Lodestar reclined, laying her back against empty air like she was resting in a lounge. "Took a long time to figure that out,

but time has proved it true. Something about my power protects my secret. With a few very powerful exceptions, it's impossible to put the pieces together unless I do it for you. Brains refuse to form the connection. Even if someone had been watching us remotely just now, it wouldn't work. They have to be physically present when I knowingly reveal myself, hence why I avoid public transformations. And before you waste a question, no, I don't have any idea how that works. Some of my abilities are harder to understand than others, and I'm still not sure I've found them all."

To Lodestar's credit, her selection of what to address first had been a fine one. Knowing the reason why her brain had been so ceaselessly bothered by Helen put a great deal of things into perspective, and also freed Tori from questioning her own deductive skills. "What's the next big question you normally knock out?"

"Actually, that one we kind of covered," Lodestar said. "The next question is usually if I'm the real Lodestar, the original, and if so, how do I look so young, but you already know that part. All that stuff I told you about my body was true, by the way. I just didn't mention what else I could do."

Behind them, shattered stone minions crumpled further, chunks of rock falling to join their brethren sprayed across the battlefield. An entire army, reduced to garbage in mere minutes. Lodestar paid it no mind, gently tapping the underside of her chin. "After that, things tend to splinter off. Different people have different concerns and reactions. Although, in these sorts of situations, they will eventually get around to asking one more identical question: why me? Why were they chosen to carry this secret?"

"You can skip that. I know a circumstantial emergency when I see one."

"Is that what you think? Tori, I had the entire run over here to change if I wanted to. Even after arriving, I could have slipped behind a tree, or waited until your back was turned. I made a choice to tell you, the same way I have with everyone I choose to share this secret with."

She wasn't entirely sure how to respond to that. Dealing with someone who wielded honesty and forthrightness so expertly compromised many of her usual social tactics. There was nothing to pry at, no secrets or shadows to take conversational refuge in. With few other options, she decided the time for being passive had drawn to a close. If Lodestar was offering answers, then Tori would take them.

"Okay, I'll bite. Why tell me?"

“Because you were afraid, even though I knew you had no reason to be. Because I’m a good judge of character, and have had plenty of time to get to know yours. Because Ivan trusts you, and that puts you in very exclusive company. There aren’t many of us.” Lodestar paused, visibly taking her time to think. “And because I wanted to. I like you, and I don’t enjoy hiding things from people I like. I wouldn’t recommend sharing it around, though.”

“Obviously. No one will even believe me if you’re not the one to show them, right?”

Lodestar seemed momentarily taken aback, though she recovered quickly. “Well, yes, that too. But mostly because of Ivan. Even despite of my power’s protections, he can be a bit overly concerned. There was a near miss some years back—story for another day—however, when the dust settled, he made it a point to crush anyone trying to uncover Lodestar’s identity.”

The story brought Tori up short, reminding her of the most insane aspect to all of this. Somehow, she had a feeling this particular tidbit wouldn’t be covered going through Lodestar’s frequently asked questions. “Yeah, on that subject, about Ivan. I mean... what the *fuck*?”

“Can you be a little more specific?”

“I honestly feel like ‘what the fuck’ summed things up pretty well.” Tori took only a moment to consider her phrasing; at this point, interest and curiosity were fast pushing diplomacy to the side. “You’re Lodestar. He is... was Fornax. The respect, I get. You were the biggest dogs on the block for a long time, the only ones who could really fight one another. But this is... it’s not just some person you used to trade blows with. You two are friends. There’s history and banter—hell, he even sang to your kid.”

A new thought entered Tori’s head, and as it did, her eyes felt like they might break their very sockets with the speed in which they expanded. “Wait a minute... your kid...”

“Let me go ahead and pause this train before it leaves the station. Ivan and I have never even come close to... you know... and therefore certainly couldn’t have offspring. Her father died before she was born, and if it’s okay, I’d like to leave it there. That’s more of a Helen question, and not an easy subject.”

It was odd, seeing sadness on the face of Lodestar, even for only a moment. “Sorry, didn’t mean to step on old wounds. Just seemed to make

the most sense when I put it all together. The idea of Lodestar letting Fornax babysit is still a bit wonky.”

“As it should be,” Lodestar said. “Because that would never happen. Helen leaning on Ivan, however, happens probably more frequently than it should. In the sense of over-imposing, I mean.” Her gaze turned softer, perhaps nearly embarrassed. “As for your ‘what the eff’ question, I guess I would describe things with Ivan as breaking a candy bar in half to pretend it has fewer calories. Perhaps not always the healthiest choice, though it does make life sweeter. I don’t have a lot of constants in this world. Ivan is a rare exception, though sometimes I worry I overburden him too much when things get choppy.”

Tori couldn’t argue much there. Ivan was nothing if not steady and reliable. Pseudonym and Fornax might be different stories, but the middle manager named Ivan Gerhardt was solid and sturdy enough to build bridges off of. “Why does he do all this...” Tori realized she knew the answer, even as she was forming the question. “Because he feels like he owes you.”

Another short flash of surprise from Lodestar, though this was less marked than before. “That’s a quick mind you’ve got there. Ivan credits me with his freedom more than he should, and given what’s associated with that freedom, he values it beyond measure. But it would be disingenuous to say that’s the root of it all. Truth be told, we even got along well in his Fornax days, when circumstance allowed for civil conversation.”

“What possible circumstances could allow for that?” Tori demanded.

“The first time was when we were chosen to represent Earth in a galactic tournament to stop it from being attacked.” Given the blasé response, Lodestar had definitely seen some form of this question coming.

Tori folded her arms. “You’re fucking with me.”

“What a thing to say. Lodestar doesn’t really lie, and she certainly doesn’t curse. Ask Ivan about it sometime. The whole thing ended up being an evil scheme we had to deal with, but there was a solid bit where Lodestar and Fornax were on the same team.” Rising from the grass, which she’d never really even touched, Lodestar stretched out her legs. “That said, since it seems like we’ve moved past the mental-panic phase of the reveal, how about we fly and talk? Since we didn’t get another monologue here and I found another gem when smashing the final boss, it seems this place has given up most of the clues it’s going to. Let’s wrap this up and get everyone home safely.”

Lodestar extended her hand, which Tori grasped. It was unnerving, the ease with which Lodestar lifted Tori up from the dirt. It was as if she had no more substance than a politician's morals; with a single motion, this slender woman could crush Tori to goop. Instead, Lodestar used that strength to pull her close and cradle her gently, taking care to ensure she would be safe as they rose higher into the air. Tori could see more of the fake world stretching out below them, and just before the wind began to howl in her ears, she made out a few half-whispered words from Lodestar.

“Much as I’m a proponent of walking softly, I think the time has come for the big stick.”

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## Chapter 87

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With dawn had come the inevitable truth that they were out of food. The last of the scrounged-up rations were doled out among the kids, water making the rounds as well. To their credit, the scouts were holding together well, but hunger was already beginning to put some on edge. Given that they were children who'd been spirited away and were slowly being starved, the fact that they'd stayed this composed was outright miraculous. Ivan couldn't expect it to hold forever.

The lie about being inside a boundary would only work until desperation defeated sense. Pressed into a survival corner, thoughts of monsters would fly out the window, a potential quick death not so bad compared to a slow, certain one. They'd go hunting for food and water, even though neither were here.

It was hard, sitting around, doing nothing, knowing the other two were out there fighting to free them. His hands ached to be fists, furious and powerful. The sidelines were never his place in battle. He belonged in the thick of things, the center of chaos and often, the cause.

Breaking off from the group she'd been talking with, Beth wandered over toward the log where Ivan was resting. Watching her approach, he realized something that should have been obvious.

That brutal position in the middle of a fray was Fornax's place. Ivan didn't belong on a battlefield. Ivan had no place slaying monsters. Given the choice in that moment, he knew he wouldn't have traded places with Helen or Tori without dire cause. Because this was where he *should* be: watching over his daughter, along with the other charges. Were he out there,

his mind and heart would be here, constantly distracted by fear for her safety. Better to be focused on the task at hand than let himself be split.

“Some of the kids are starting to get really scared.” She sat down next to him, keeping her voice to polite, if not covert, levels. “I keep telling them we’ll be saved, but between the noises and the darkness, last night was hard. Being hungry isn’t helping. I hope they’ll be okay until it’s over.”

Even in a situation like this one, Beth was more concerned for everyone else. Ivan patted her head, wondering for the umpteenth time how he and Janet had managed to produce these wonderful children. “I suppose that means you’re not scared at all.”

“A little,” Beth admitted. “But that seems selfish. I’ve got my power and my dad here. Nobody else has either. If I can’t be brave, it’ll only make the others more scared.”

The hug was unexpected, as the best ones often are. Beth’s tiny arms encircled his ribs, clutching him tightly, expressing all the fear she was hiding from the others in one single, powerful embrace. “And I know we’ll be okay. Even if Lodestar doesn’t find a way to save us, my daddy always comes through.”

Sitting on that log, Ivan hugged his daughter back, thankful that no one who actually knew him was around to see the swirl of emotions storm across his face. One way or another, they were getting out of this trap. Helen would find a way eventually, but if time ran short, then Ivan would think of something. Destruction was his talent, his burden, his medium. There had to be something he could break to get them out.

Until then, he comforted his daughter, and reminded himself that he wasn’t sitting on his ass doing nothing. Ivan was waiting for the inevitable. Lodestar would defeat this place, just like she’d defeated every meta Ivan had ever seen take a swing. It’s what she did, and frustrating as that was when set against her, the notion offered a great deal of comfort as one under her care.

It was only a matter of waiting until this labyrinth broke open and Fornax was set free to hunt down the perpetrators. For now, he simply threw all of himself into being Ivan. Each version had a time and a place. Fornax’s would come—probably much too soon for perpetrators. Ivan only hoped he’d have enough self-control to take his time. They’d made his daughter afraid. That earned them the slowest death he could provide.



Something was wrong.

Lozora hung near the edge of the campgrounds, away from the prying eyes of police and capes, just near enough to keep an eye on the floating orb suspended above the track. The sun had fallen and returned, yet still no one had come out. By the estimations they'd been working from, the trap was expected to hold a fully motivated Fornax for only a few hours, ideally. Finding out exactly how long it would take was the whole point of the test; however, this was well outside the bounds of expectation.

With his kid at risk, Fornax would have had to move at top speeds, even if he trusted his apprentice to watch over her. The whole thing should have been done before midnight on the first day, based on what they'd been able to find on Fornax's estimated speed. A few hours here or there was variance, but they were coming up on a full day since the trap had sprung. If Fornax had left the kids alone for that long, odds were at least a few had already been lost, possibly the apprentice, too. What really sent shivers down the cartilage system that functioned as Lozora's spine was the possibility that his daughter was among that kill count.

Crossing Fornax had been a calculated risk, one Lozora didn't take lightly. It was why she'd been careful not to be seen or implicated in any way, and had advocated for a plan that put the kid in as minimal danger as possible. Because the underworld still whispered about the remains of those who crossed Fornax; even now, the Order of the Final Dawn's massacre was told like a bogeyman's tale. Though it wasn't known what they'd done to cross Fornax, he had wiped them from the face of the Earth: every last member, killed and butchered past even the most potent forms of meta-restoration.

Lozora was growing torn with every hour that ticked by. The more she lingered, the greater her chances of discovery, linking her to this crime. But if she fled before seeing the experiment's conclusion, her employer would be aggressively displeased. Despite his attitude already wearing thin on her nerves, Lozora had put in too much to walk away from the endeavor now. Besides, she wanted to see how one of the old legends worked—the ones who never bent a knee to those damned capes.

In the end, it was a matter of weighing risks. While Fornax might be coming out furious, so long as Lozora remained unseen, he'd never know



she had a hand in it. Whereas her employer was expecting results and a report, which made him the more pressing danger. Still, it was hard not to wonder just what the hell was going on inside that orb.



“Subtle, it isn’t.” The massive crater in the ground looked like a sunken amphitheater, with four grooves chopping it into equal quarters. All of it was made of stone, with visible sections that would probably flip over, revealing the inevitable minions within. It was smaller than the series of rings, which Tori found curious until she remembered how weak those had been compared to the first challenge. So far, the labyrinth had tested its prisoners against a single potent threat and many smaller ones. Logically, the next step would be multiple strong enemies.

“If I didn’t know better, I’d think it was a trap within a trap. Ivan steps in, puts the gems on those raised chunks in the center, the whole thing locks down after he’s worn out from the earlier fights.” Lodestar hovered in the air, Tori still clutched carefully, surveying the land—though for what, Tori could only guess. They hadn’t seen much in the flight over. All roads seemed to lead here; one more sign that they were on the right trail.

“I guess he would have been taking this faster, with no rests in between,” Tori agreed.

Slowly, they began to lower, still a ways off from the giant stone pit. “That wouldn’t matter, not against enemies like this. Even if the challenge were great enough that it did briefly work, all it would do is make him mad. No prison can withstand him for long.”

“Except Rookstone, obviously.” Tori waited, expecting to hear quick confirmation. Instead, she got a very precisely phrased statement.

“In a sense, yes. Ivan never escaped from Rookstone.”

With the ground rushing up, it would have been easy to miss the careful parsing of words, but Tori was feeling reenergized and alert after the shocking revelation, along with some time to rest. “That’s not the same thing as him being unable to, is it?”

There was scarcely even a jostle as Lodestar landed, lowering Tori onto her own two feet. “No, it’s not. I hope you’ll understand why we don’t broadcast that, though. If people knew there was a meta that jail couldn’t

technically hold, they'd push for more permanent solutions to be used, and trying that with Fornax, among others, would largely end in bloodshed."

"Trust me, I want the public getting execution-happy with villains even less than you do. Does make me wonder: if Rookstone didn't keep Ivan held, then why did he stay? Fornax broke into and out of government installations before."

"The answer is simple, and exceedingly complicated, depending on how deep one digs. You'll have to do with the succinct version, since we're in a hurry: Ivan stayed because I beat him. Defeated him, I should say. We threw down for real. I proved to be better, and that was my prize. Even as Fornax, he always had his pride. That was why he agreed to the terms, and honored them upon losing. Pride was the only cage I ever found that worked on Fornax, and not even that weakness exists anymore."

"You think Ivan doesn't have pride?" Had those words come from anyone else, Tori might have flushed with anger, but Lodestar knew her teacher better than Tori could even begin to guess. There had to be some meaning to her words outside the obvious read of it as an insult.

"Heavens no, I'm not blind," she corrected. "The *weakness* of it no longer exists. Ivan will cast his pride, his dignity, even his life aside without a second thought when the need is real. If he were suddenly thrown back into Rookstone under similar circumstances, it would only last until the first time Rick or Beth needed help. Pride like that means nothing compared to guarding the ones we love."

Lodestar reached out, taking Tori's hands carefully, giving them a squeeze. "I know, at the outset, this world can be confusing. The labels and legends all seem like they mean so much, the distinctions between cape and villain appear as chasms between us. But here's the truth as I've best discovered: when things get serious, you'll know who your friends are."

"Ah, so we're circling back to Cyber Geek and the New Science Sentries." Tori didn't pull her hands away just yet, even if she was slightly tempted.

"We're circling back to the young woman who told me she didn't think she could keep being friends with people because of circumstance. If that's your choice, then so be it. I just want to make sure you know the decision you're making. The longer you live like this, the less the labels matter. You realize that jerks will chase the glory of being a superhero and good people can end up on the path of villainy. At the end of the day, you'll know who

your friends are, because when things inevitably get bad, they'll be the ones you want to protect. The people who, when you see them in danger, a deep, primal part of you simply says **No**. The world can't have them, can't *take* them. Not while you're there to intervene. You can choose to ignore it, if you like, but you'll never be free of wondering what might have been, had you been a little more honest with yourself and fought when the chance was present."

She released her gentle grip on Tori's hands, looking away quickly, albeit not quite quick enough. "Those the words of experience?" Tori asked.

"Too much experience, honestly. There are days I see why most Lodestars don't last as long as I have." Quickly changing the subject, Lodestar turned back toward the stone circle, gaze turning determined. "So what do you say we put a wrap on this thing? It's either the last trial, or meant to look like it, which means there will probably be some sort of surprise trick. Any thoughts?"

"It's made with Fornax in mind, so my main guess would be violent as hell."

Lodestar licked her finger, shot up into the air a few feet, then dropped back down. "No artificial wind this time. You feeling up to being my eyes in the sky?"

"Hell yes. Here I was thinking I'd have to sit on the sidelines." There was a part of Tori that wondered how essential she could truly be, given who she'd be watching over, but she swiftly dispelled that doubt. This was, after all, a matter of not just getting things done, but getting them done quickly. If her efforts saved even a few minutes for Lodestar, it meant they'd be getting the kids out of danger that much faster.

That was, obviously, the reason Tori was excited as she shifted to fire form and took to the air. As a proper villain, it certainly wouldn't have been anything as silly as the chance to fight alongside a living legend. Well... perhaps Ivan might get some insight into her actual motivations, once the dust had settled.

If anyone could understand, she had a pretty good hunch it would be him.

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## Chapter 88

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Overhead, the scene looked the same as it had floating with Lodestar, only a bit less stable. Tori's tactic of flight didn't allow for the same precision when hovering—not that it mattered much, as she was currently flying rings around the area as Lodestar made her approach toward the pit. The legendary superhero was taking the ground route this time, just like Ivan probably would have. No shifts as Lodestar approached, even when she drew within touching distance of the caveless stalagmite in the stone crater's center.

Pausing to give Tori a brief look, Lodestar placed both gems into grooves on the ground's upward protrusion, each clicking instantly into place.

For as well as she was rolling with the shock, Tori still hadn't fully adjusted to the Helen-Lodestar connection. Even as Tori watched her step into the pit, it was hard to fathom that this was really the same person. The woman who'd hit the dance floor like a tornado of elbows, coordinated constant craft projects, and spent half the night talking about old movies was the most powerful superhero known to Earth. All that saved her from wasting time denying the obvious was knowing that Fornax turned out to be a dependable middle manager, a devoted dad, and a surprisingly skilled cook. Tori was in deep enough now to know that the mask and who was under it didn't always match up, though this *still* felt like a bit much.

Her interest in speculation fell away as movement came from the stone surface. Shifting rocks fired out of the ground, encircling Lodestar, then briefly blocking her from view as they locked together. In the center of each

quadrant, a tower appeared, stretching roughly ten feet into the air. One by one, as they completed, small metal objects appeared from hidden compartments in the very top. The whole process took less than ten seconds, and when it was done, Tori was shocked to hear the mysterious voice echo up from below.

“Well done, Fornax. I’m sure you’ve had a great deal of fun smashing through what must seem like rudimentary obstacles. To escape, however, I’m afraid you’ll need something not normally associated with your skill set: delicacy. Around you, I’m sure you’ve noticed the four pillars that have risen. Atop each is a small puzzle, a minor mental challenge at best, yet you’ll need every bit of focus to see the task through. You see, if any of those pillars are destroyed, the labyrinth will self-destruct. Such an explosion wouldn’t be enough to kill you, obviously. Anyone else trapped inside likely won’t be so lucky.”

As the voice was talking, Tori realized the stones on the ground hadn’t stopped moving. They were still shifting, and from within the dark spaces, she saw flashes of movement. She started to call out a warning, but unfortunately, her words were drowned out by the loud voice resuming.

“You also won’t be the only one in there. We’ve got plenty more minions for you to play with—though, if you’re too occupied, they’ll happily attack the towers instead.” The first of the new enemies emerged, and for a moment, Tori almost mistook it for a living being; the lizard-like body paired with stretches of moss along the joints created a believable image, at least until it opened its mouth, revealing rows of sharp, gray stone fangs.

“To ensure you continue working with the expediency we’ve come to expect, let’s properly motivate you not to dilly-dally. I think one minute per tower is fair. In fact, we’ll round up to an even five.”

The center of the pit at last opened up, revealing a modestly sized hourglass. No sooner had it touched the artificial sunlight than the sands began to fall. “Five minutes until everything is annihilated, unless a tower is destroyed or forbidden power used, in which case, it happens immediately. Let us see how the great legend fairs with a task beyond pure destruction.”

By the time Tori looked back from the hourglass, there was already a spray of stone appendages next to Lodestar, where the first rock-lizard had popped up. More were crawling out across the pit, spacing themselves in what sure seemed to be purposeful inconvenience. Had Ivan been alone, the

task would have been trying for him. Kill enough to get breathing room, work on a puzzle, rinse, repeat. Without being called, Tori was already dropping back down. Strong as Lodestar was, she was still a single cape, and with super-speed off the table, they had to pick where best to use her.

“You go low. I’ll go high!” Tori all but fell onto the first tower, halting her descent with a powerful blast at the very end. She dared not shift more than her hands to flesh—every pound added increased the work needed to stay airborne, not to mention presented a target for any ambitious enemies. Behind her were the sounds of sneakers skidding, the shatter of rock, but her eyes stayed focused on the puzzle at hand.

It wasn’t an especially complex task. With only her first few glances, Tori could see the solution. The test was one of precision more than mental acuity: everything had to be lined up near-perfect to untwist the central cylinder. First try, no luck. Second try, another failure. A spray of shards clipped through the flames of her back, and Tori worked to put the rest of the world out of her mind. This wasn’t taking on a meta out of her league or demanding a power she lacked; Tori could do this. It was a test of her ability to concentrate, to think under pressure. That task was within her reach. Failing because she lacked power was one thing. Failing because she couldn’t do the damn job—now that was another matter entirely. She mentally pulled back, letting herself take a fresh run at the attempt, just like she had a snagged pole during tent setup.

On her third try, the cylinder twisted, and as it did, the entire puzzle began to dissolve. They didn’t get much more “done” than that, so Tori tore back into the air, eyes already hunting for the next tower. Looking around, she was dumbstruck by the number of broken bodies surrounding her position. Evidently, the goons came out in mass when a puzzle was being solved. What would Ivan have done, if he’d really been here all alone? Yank up the whole floor and kill the whole army at once? The notion seemed ludicrous, yet also worryingly plausible.

Hovering near the second tower, Tori noticed that the next puzzle was different from the first. Not unexpected, though part of her had hoped they’d all be the same, since the real test was in the execution. No such luck, so she began to twist the various symbols on the cube, deciphering the pattern as she went. Again, the solution was relatively easy to see, harder to reach. Every movement created countermovements that had to be accounted for. This one, she actually had an easier time with than the first; after all the

half-rigged inventions she'd had to keep functioning, working with the overall project vision in mind and thinking several steps ahead were skills she'd polished to a shine.

Flashes of light in her periphery meant that Lodestar was busting out blasts of energy. Tori wrapped up the second puzzle just in time to see flecks of debris hit the ground where presumably a squadron of enemies had stood previously. This time, there were also still a few rock-lizards prowling around, though none near her tower. Lodestar wouldn't have any reason to be slowing down, so the rate they were appearing had to be increasing. Without using her super-speed, there was a limit to how quickly she'd be able to fell them. No wonder she'd switched over to wider-reaching attacks.

As Tori zipped over to the next tower, her vision wandered across the hourglass, which was shedding sand at a worrying rate. Had it really been nearly half the time already, or was it picking up as she cleared each challenge? She had a feeling the voice would pull that stuff, but Helen had been adamant about Cobblord's standards as a creator. Hopefully, accurate timers were part of that.

This time, she found herself staring at a spiked ball where each spike could be twisted anywhere between 180 – 360 degrees. After turning the first few, she was able to pick up on the different sounds each made upon hitting its latches. From there, it was a simple matter of finding the universal noise and dialing all of the spikes to it. Simple, but tedious, and with lots of room for reckless error. In a way, she had to hand it to the designer; given the time and distractions, Ivan really would have had trouble with this, even as detail-oriented as he was. Then again, if he failed, the creator would have a vengeful Fornax with a daughter to avenge, so maybe this wasn't such a great plan after all.

That assumed the threat was genuine, and since they clearly couldn't risk dismissing such a possibility, she had to proceed as though it wasn't a bluff. Whether it truly was or not, she hoped to never find out, dropping the third puzzle as soon as it began to dissolve. Firing away, she scanned the battlefield as she crossed to her final destination.

Save only for the patches where more minions were emerging, Tori could no longer see the ground. It was completely covered by the broken bodies of those that had come before. Like someone had driven a semi through a hall of statues, untold rock limbs lay shattered in piles,

surrounding a Lodestar who continued to glow, untouched and unmarred by the relentless assault. Sadly, the hourglass wasn't so unaffected. Her time was definitely running short.

Coming down hard, Tori accidentally put a flaming leg into the tower, causing a dark stain along the stone. She pulled back quickly, all attention on the final puzzle: a series of thin rings, brittle enough they'd easily snap, interwoven with strategic gaps in each one. Lining them up required getting the angles precise, and then carefully controlling the force used to pull them apart. There was nothing that said breaking it was against the rules, but given the circumstances, some limitations could be inferred. For as quickly as Tori found the solution, she also realized there was an issue. Hovering roughly had been fine for the first three; however, this task demanded a perfectly steady hand. She couldn't do it while bobbing in the air.

"Going full human. Please keep those things at bay." It was scary, shifting back fully to her human self, grabbing onto one of the many decorative spires along the tower's top, putting her safety entirely in the hands of a cape. Although, if she was trusting herself to any superhero, it would have been hard to pick a better candidate.

Wrapping her legs around the tower's center for stability, Tori didn't bother looking over to the hourglass. At this point, she had the time she had; knowing wouldn't change anything. Working as fast as she dared, one by one Tori pulled the rings apart. A rock whizzed by near her head as she separated the next-to-last pieces, strings of curses filling her mind, then dying on the tongue. Even moving her jaw was unnecessary, and right now, stability mattered more than anything else.

The final two rings had the thinnest of openings, because of course this shit couldn't be easy. Tori shut out the sounds of battle, the protests of pain from her already worn legs, the absolute insanity of her situation overall. She did what she'd always been able to do: close off the world, narrow it to the project before her. Everything else was ancillary. All that mattered was what existed in her hands. With more dexterity than she'd have believed her fingers capable of, the final rings pulled softly apart, neither breaking from the force.

Seconds later, they began to dissolve, though this time, the puzzle wasn't alone. The tower was doing the same thing, as were the bodies Lodestar had beaten. And the active minions, now that Tori was looking around, along with the stone pit and the ground surrounding them. The



whole landscape was rippling, like it had been painted on a waterbed that had just been jumped upon.

Before she could shift back, Tori found herself suddenly weightless as Lodestar flew them both up into the air. “Pretty sure it will float us back down, but better safe than sorry. If we start descending normally, I’ll let you enjoy the ride.”

“What if we all come out of here dropping?”

“Then Lodestar will miraculously swoop in to catch everyone. No more labyrinth rules means I don’t have to hold back anymore, and I’m pretty quick when I need to be. Don’t worry, I’ll set you down as well. There’s no need to show anyone your powers unless you choose to.”

The words were comforting, despite watching the ground crack and shake below them. Relief was flooding Tori’s system; this ordeal truly did seem to be over. Unfortunately, Tori wasn’t so short-sighted that she couldn’t see there was more on the horizon. Being let in on Lodestar’s secret wasn’t a minor thing, no matter how the cape herself had tried to downplay it. There was also the fact that the weekend’s events constituted a direct, knowing attack on guild leadership. People were going to pay for this, and to her surprise, Tori realized she wanted to be in the thick of it.

That was as far as her thought process went before the world around them suddenly sucked briefly inward, and then exploded.

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## Chapter 89

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One moment, they were gathered in the forest, and then suddenly the ground was shaking. There was barely any time to react before the whole world they were standing on shattered, sending them all flying into what seemed like the sky. The false veneer quickly gave way, opening up to reveal the genuine outdoors. Loud booms were echoing across the campgrounds as the walls of condensed space collapsed, sending out minor shockwaves.

Mercifully, the same effect that had been used during their capture was still functioning, floating them down slowly. Ivan scanned for Beth and found her nearby, holding the hands of several other campers. He readied himself to teleport if gravity suddenly kicked into gear before noticing a familiar light streaking through the sky.

“Oh my god, it’s her.”

“Look! It’s Lodestar!”

“Lodestar saved us!”

The kids were yelling now, moving toward cheering, and it wasn’t as if they were wrong. Whether as herself or as Helen, Lodestar had indeed saved the day. Ivan had a great deal of questions for her on how, but resolved himself to waiting. Up here, he could already see the small crowd watching their descent. Her first job would be to update the AHC—official information channels took priority over secret friendships, especially considering she wouldn’t want Ivan to get ahead of her on this one. Both had reason to want the perpetrators, but each would have very different plans for what to do with them.

Catching Beth's attention, Ivan gestured to the streaking light, to which he received a few quickly mouthed words: "You were right."

Ivan tried his very best to etch that memory into his brain. If Rick's teen years were any indication, he wouldn't be hearing those words again anytime soon.

As the ground drew nearer, Ivan assessed the crowd, searching for the other missing Starscout personnel. It wasn't hard, as Tori turned out to be less than thirty feet away as they were landing. There was no way she'd been that close when the orb split; although, in all that streaking about, no one would have noticed if Lodestar moved one body to a different position in the sky.

While Lodestar continued to circle the kids as they descended, ensuring that each one landed safely, Tori darted over, grabbing Ivan.

"Glad to see you're okay," he greeted her. "Everything go smoothly?"

"Oh boy, just so much to unpack and tell you about. But first things first, there's some stuff you need to know about what just happened."

With a quick glance, Ivan confirmed there was no one directly near them; however, in the chaos, that could change at any moment. "Perhaps this could wait until we have a more private location?"

"Ivan... you were the target. The old you. Whoever did this knows who you really are, and they also know about Beth."

A different Ivan, one not somewhat tired from a day-long ordeal, not facing down the very apprentice he'd worked so hard to educate on the importance of control, would have potentially ruined an entire swatch of forest with the surge of violent power that rose up inside him. But this was an Ivan who knew the value of control, and of pointing one's vengeance in the proper direction. None of these people deserved to bear his wrath. That would be reserved for the ones who'd incurred it. He could scarcely wait.

"Tell me what I need to know."



By early Sunday evening, the news was pouring from all major outlets: someone had attempted to attack a Starscout event. It had, of course, ended in failure. Details on how they'd been saved were light, but with Lodestar herself appearing on the scene right as the orb shattered and gently dropped

its prisoners back to the ground, some assumptions were obvious. Images of slightly dirty children flickered across multiple screens, along with the stern face of Lodestar.

“While we don’t have any perpetrators in custody yet, let me assure you, this is a crime the Alliance of Heroic Champions, and I, personally, take quite seriously.” Those damned eyes looked right down the camera, like she could see the man going by Wendel Worthington watching in his lair. “I would advise the perpetrators to turn themselves in. Barring that, my recommendation would be to enjoy what freedom you have left. Very soon, you’ll be in court—”

He muted the audio feed; threats held no interest for him. His only concern had been the results of the experiment, and whether or not Lozora had been apprehended. Evidently not. If they had a lead to parade in front of the camera, the AHC absolutely would. That was one silver lining; he didn’t need to replace his pawn so close to the real game. Unfortunately, the experiment itself had been a massive failure. With Lodestar in the mix, there was no telling if Ivan had even finished the labyrinth himself, or what his speed would be.

Resting on his desk sat a large hunk of rare metal similar in hue to the orb Lozora had been given, yet not quite the same. This was to be material for Cobblord’s second draft, a refined version. They could still make it—catching another kid to put in there as the limiter wouldn’t be too hard. Hell, it probably didn’t even have to be Ivan’s own child. The so-called legend had never possessed the ruthlessness to ascend beyond his limitations. But without knowing for certain if it could hold Fornax long enough, the whole effort was useless.

In his youth, this man would have pressed on with the compromised effort. He would have looked at the resources spent, the time and money used to procure these items, and decided it would be folly not to use them. Life and experience had taught him much, including the concept of a sunk-cost fallacy. What mattered wasn’t the work put in, but the results obtained. Fornax had to be occupied; otherwise, the whole plan could come apart.

Working the shadows, scheming in secret, it all only held together for so long. Too many villains tried to make this phase last forever rather than accepting what it was: a chance to prepare. Sooner or later, the truth always spilled out, and once it did, there would be a reckoning. Using this time to

get ready, to smooth out the path toward his objectives as much as possible, meant that when things did change, he'd still have the upper hand.

If the labyrinth couldn't be counted on, then his best bet was to roll Fornax into the same distraction planned for the AHC. It would shift the timetables, perhaps significantly, but so long as he was efficient, the rest of the plan was still viable. He only needed enough time to do the job and slip away. The real challenge would be forcing himself not to savor the act he'd spent so much work laying a foundation for. Although, this was more about the message than the killing itself, an inherited grudge the owner had no idea had been hung over their head.

Lifting a phone, those thin fingers stalked along the buttons, the anti-tracking equipment wired in making the process slightly cumbersome. It was time to make sure the Guild of Villainous Reformation knew exactly what it was they'd no doubt been tracking for some time now, along with what was hidden from their sensors. Once the guild knew what was coming, they'd have to take steps to interfere, most likely leading with the tip of their spear: Fornax.

After all, this was their world, too. It wasn't as if they could afford to shrug off an impending invasion.



Beth was asleep before she even made it to her room, nodding off on the couch while Ivan brought Janet up to speed. Rick and Juan were out fetching dinner when they arrived, offering Beth a quiet place to rest—probably not a coincidence. Given the look on his ex-wife's face, Ivan imagined this wasn't a conversation she wanted lots of people to be around for. He'd expected to have to wait until Beth wore down; however, a weekend of stress and poor sleep made itself known the instant she felt at home, sending her soaring into slumber.

Nearby, in the kitchen, Janet kept her voice low and controlled, a well-honed skill from their married days, when these discussions were far more frequent. "What the *hell* happened out there?"

"It's like the news says. Someone tossed a maze, and it snagged all of us. I made sure the kids were safe, while the others worked to get us out."

“Uh huh. ‘Someone’ threw a maze. Weird, how they’d use a device worth millions to the right buyer on a Starscout cluster, run by a middle manager and a whatever-she-pretends-to-be. Just admit it, they were picking a fight with her, and our daughter got caught in the middle, like I always warned you she would.” Janet glanced into the living room, making sure the kid in question was still resting. “Well this is the last straw. Tomorrow, we are going to explain to Beth—”

“It was me,” Ivan interrupted. He didn’t want to agitate her by being rude, but Janet could also be hard to derail once she had momentum going. Better to get the truth out while it was still capable of being considered. “We don’t know much yet, but I was able to exchange a few words with Tori after the release. Enough to be aware that *I* was the target, and Beth being in there wasn’t a coincidence.”

Her head of steam died slowly as Ivan’s words sank in. What took its place was far worse, in Ivan’s esteem. Janet was past angry, the heat of rage giving way to the pure, unrelenting cold of true fury. When she spoke again, it was with the sort of unnerving calm that had always intrigued Ivan. The facet was, in honesty, part of what had formed their initial attraction.

“You promised me this wouldn’t happen. You looked me in the eyes, and you told me they’d stay away. That your identity was secret enough, and even the few who did find out would keep clear. Because no one would *dare* mess with Fornax, or the ones he loves.”

The words were all but a slap, and Ivan glanced over himself to be sure that Beth was still conked out. Using that name in her home was not something Janet did lightly.

“Don’t think for a moment that I wanted—”

“Our baby just got dragged into an orb in the goddamn sky, I don’t give a *fuck* what you want.” It was Janet’s turn to interrupt, and she hissed the words—likely the only way she could resist from screaming them. “You know I want? I want to spend tonight with my husband and kids, having a nice dinner, not calling a child psychologist who specializes in meta-related trauma. I want to not see that suspicious glint in Rick’s eyes every time he looks at either of us these days. I want to stop lying awake every single night wondering when it will all come crashing down, when your secret gets out and their lives become insane—assuming they’re lucky enough to make it through. I want our children to be safe, Ivan.”

She finally paused, taking a moment to compose herself. Only once Ivan was sure she'd said her piece did he speak once more. "As do I. More than anything in the world. There is nothing I won't do to protect those two."

"Except, apparently, your current plan isn't working. This is the second time in a calendar year our kids have been targeted because of you." Janet was looking more centered now, the initial shock of the revelation giving way to her relentless thought. She seemed to take him in as he stood there, looking over every detail of the aggressively mundane appearance. Her tone softened considerably. "Ivan, no one, not even *her*, knows better than I do how hard you worked to leave Fornax behind when Rick arrived. Whatever issues we might have, you have always been an amazing father to those kids, and I am wowed by the transformation you made. But maybe... maybe right now, they don't need their father as much as they need the demon he used to be."

The words came out heavy, as such a sentiment should be. She never looked away, however. Janet knew what she was saying, asking, in a way that very few could. "People aren't afraid the way they once were. Achievements have turned into history, stories into myths. You did such a good job living in the shadows that Fornax's legend faded."

"Your solution is that I take revenge for this incident, I assume?" Ivan wasn't entirely sure how he felt about the idea she was floating; instead, he focused on making it through the conversation. It had been a very long weekend. He dearly needed some time to decompress.

"Revenge? The kind where your people show up and the perpetrators are never heard from again? No, Ivan. This demands more than death from the shadows. This needs to be a spectacle." Ivan felt a slight chill at Janet's steady, unwavering gaze. "Crack their bones, sear their skin, drop their severed heads onto the tables of their closest allies. *Break* these pieces of shit, the way only the great destroyer can, and make sure the world sees. Show them what happens to anyone who goes against Fornax."

Between the two of them, Ivan was undeniably the greater danger. Even without his meta-human abilities, he had a lifetime of combat training and the willingness to do harm in ways most people could never obtain. However, that didn't mean Janet was some shrinking violet, content to live in willful ignorance. Protecting her children always came first. She knew

full well what she was asking, and there wasn't so much as a flicker of doubt.

"If I do something like that, the AHC is going to turn the heat way up. There might be unexpected consequences."

"Glad you mentioned them, actually," Janet replied. "Reminds me—pass a message along to *her*: I want to have a word."

That was a bad idea. A terrible idea, for an abundance of reasons, none of which Ivan could find a tactful way to bring up. Ultimately, he decided to stall for time until he could think of something. "I'll let her know, but she's often busy. Might be a while before she responds."

"Tell her to use that damn super-speed. The way she should have inside that stupid maze, so a bunch of kids wouldn't have spent a weekend being kidnapped."

Though Ivan had gotten a rough outline of the labyrinth's setup and limitations during his brief talk with Tori, he declined to bring any of it up. For the moment, Janet was angry and scared; the facts weren't going to matter. Ivan understood that all too well, because he was feeling exactly the same thing. The fact that Beth had been included on purpose terrified him down to his very core. Life was so fleeting, so easily snatched away, and he couldn't bear the thought of anything happening to either of his kids.

Which was why the anger inside was taking significant effort to hold back. Janet was freer with her emotions, because she could afford to be. Harsh words weren't the same as what slipped loose when Ivan's control wavered. Worse, part of him was already wondering if Janet was right. Was his best move to dole out this punishment publicly? The Apollo fight was a slipup; he hadn't willingly acted as Fornax in years. Perhaps that was part of the reason these new threats felt so emboldened.

Janet had raised some valid points, yet Ivan still remained hesitant. Not because he didn't relish the idea of setting a violent, bloody example of what happened to those who crossed his family—in fact, it was an image he was actively working to keep out of his head. Being Fornax again would be easy, which was why Ivan still felt the need to resist.

Once Fornax was intentionally let out, there might be no putting him back.



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## Chapter 90

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Tori was surprised to see an empty street corner as the car dropped her off. She'd been expecting some of the New Science Sentries to be there, so over-concerned that they insisted on walking her the few feet from sidewalk to front door. Hauling herself out of the car, she looked her brick domicile up and down, appreciating the familiarity. It had taken a while, but arriving here was starting to feel like coming home. Especially knowing that she had friends up there waiting for her.

It was probably a good thing none of the capes were around. Tori still wasn't sure how she felt about learning Lodestar's secret, or the implications it had regarding Ivan, and some time to think through that would be nice. Besides, she needed to reconsider her stance on fraternizing with capes as a whole. The friendships that had seemed so impossible on Friday weren't nearly as remarkable by comparison now, which made them feel far more manageable.

Stepping into the foyer, Tori caught movement from the mail alcove. It wasn't especially subtle, as the figure moved toward her as soon as she appeared. For an instant, her heart leapt at the sight of those kaleidoscope eyes, but the same bit could only be genuinely scary so many times.

"Nexus, you are one creepy bastard, you know that?"

"If only," he replied, sounding oddly... wistful? "How was your weekend?"

"What, weren't you posted up on a tree somewhere, watching the whole thing?"

Nexus shook his head hard, causing his long trench coat to shake slightly, sending off small plumes of red dirt. “Others to watch, and Lodestar fights are boring unless they’re big. Like... well, odds are you’ll see soon enough.”

“Great, I’ll set my DVR. Anything else, or is this just your creepy hangout for the night?” She should be more scared—Tori knew that rationally. Mad as he seemed, Nexus had endured the full efforts of the guild and the AHC to stamp him out. He was capable of wide-scale destruction like she could only imagine, based on the few displays he’d given.

“One thing, if you’re interested.” Nexus was smiling in a way that only the truly gleeful and insane could manage: with absolute abandon. “A junction is looming, a point where things tend to go in one of two directions. In one version, several fascinating stories are cut short. In another, they persist, providing more entertainment. The difference in the two is often you.”

The unnerving thing about Nexus was that he was mad, not crazy. There *was* logic in those shattered eyes, a process of thought and reason that guided his actions. After a few meetings, she’d gotten enough clues to realize that, at least for now, he was largely acting as a voyeur. Their world was amusing to him, so he watched it for entertainment. Tracking that, when he said stories were cut short... he was probably talking about the people living those tales.

“Who gets hurt?”

“Can’t say. Not always the same, you know. But they won’t be strangers to you, that much is certain.”

It was never that easy. Just enough information to make you do what they wanted: that was how manipulators loved to work. She was very tempted to flip him the bird and walk away, except that afterward, every time she looked at Beverly or Chloe, Tori would wonder if something bad was coming for them, and whether she could have stopped it.

“You can’t tell me who is involved, or what will happen, I’m guessing. But somehow, I affect the outcome?”

“A superhero defends what is just; a villain defends what is theirs. Remember who you truly are, and the rest shall flow as it does. I have my preferences, but the show marches on regardless.” He twirled once, his massive coat flaring out behind. “Do try to keep it amusing.”

Without warning, he was simply gone. Never with flash or spectacle, Nexus moved through space with the same level of grandiose display as when Tori took a step forward. It was mundane to him, as was likely all of this. Who knew how much those fractured eyes had witnessed, and over a span of how long? Yet something impending was fascinating enough to warrant a special trip to Tori. These did happen—she'd been warned as much since he crashed a guild meeting.

Tori's plans for an evening of rest suddenly evaporated as she found a fresh wind. Dinner with her friends, certainly, but after that, it was down to the lab. The Hephaestus suit needed repairing, and she no longer felt safe with it compromised. Something told her she was going to be wearing it again sooner than later.

Curiously, Tori realized this notion had put a thin smile on the edges of her lips. Perhaps Nexus wasn't the only one capable of acclimating to the insanity of this lifestyle.



“Any idea what this is about?” Donald followed Ren through the crowd, his friend's bulk helping clear a path through the array of costumed forms. He couldn't recall ever seeing so many of the AHC's capes in one place. Usually, they were separated by schedules and distance; with a whole world to keep running and only so many capes to lean on, they weren't exactly all walking the same patrol beat. Most of the others seemed excited, though a few appeared nervous.

“I got the same text as you. Major meeting—everyone not on active assignments who can get here needs to report.” Ren halted his forward march, having reached the end of space in the crowd. Moving more would demand shoving bodies aside; hardly a polite option, especially around coworkers. This room was enormous, as was the screen dominating an entire wall. Still, even with all the space, they were getting packed in. The AHC had evidently grown since the room was last needed for this purpose.

Scanning the room, Donald noted Irene and Lucy coming in from their individual training sessions. Both were still clad in sweats rather than costumes, Lucy waving as soon as they made eye contact. The two began

wading through the sea of bodies, though how long it would take to reach their position was anyone's guess.

Turning his attention toward the front, where the screen was located, he picked out the familiar hue of the New Science Sentries' costumes, all four of them in prime positions. They must have either gotten here in advance or used Presto's teleportation trickery—probably the former. Austin didn't seem the sort to let his people cut ahead. There were other familiar outfits near the front, as well: Dapper Doll, the Ineffable, Glass Cannon, and the unfortunately named Mister Fister, a brawling cape who must be working very hard to ignore the innuendo of his moniker.

At the next figure, Donald almost let out a yelp of shock. Sure enough, that was Lady Shade standing there. She'd been missing since the rebellion. He'd assumed she was booted along with the other traitors. Maybe telling the truth at the end had bought her some leniency? That was more comforting than his other hunch: that they were up against something so dangerous, it demanded all hands on deck. Even the untrusted ones.

Suddenly, the lights flickered, blinking three times. Instantly, the crowd grew silent as every eye turned toward the giant screen. After the third bout of darkness, the lights remained off. What illuminated the room now was a bright, blank screen. Seconds later, Professor Quantum stepped onto the stage, followed by Quorum. Lodestar arrived a few steps behind, her tardiness probably the result of still having to deal with the fallout from the Starscout attack. Donald had sent Tori a text—the most he could do with this meeting filling up his evening. Besides, knowing her, she probably wanted to be alone and relax. Tori would reach out when she was ready; he just hoped his schedule would open up when the moment came.

"Superheroes of the Alliance of Heroic Champions," Professor Quantum began, "today I stand before you with grave news. The purpose for which this organization was founded, to defend the world against threats great and small, shall be put to its fullest test once again. While much of what I'm about to say will eventually leak to the public, it is vital this remain confidential for as long as possible. Failure to control information could lead to mass panic and civilian casualties."

The light, interested vibe of the room shifted quickly. Professor Quantum was never what one would call carefree, but the gravity of these words was undeniable. He was serious, as was their situation. "We have been tracking a migration of ships moving on a course for Earth. These are

not Grzzniltan, though we suspect they had some hand in this. Based on information provided by our extraterrestrial sources, we believe these to be the Wrexwren, a species specialized in conquering and combat. Considering their attempt at a stealthy approach and the number of ships present, this is almost certainly an invading force.”

Someone in the room obviously had the ability to steal the bottom out from people’s stomachs: that was the only explanation Donald could think of for why his gut suddenly dropped to the heels of his shoes. An invasion? An actual attempt to take over their planet? That was crazy. It had been forever since the last time anyone tried that, and the AHC had sent them packing. Which was exactly what Professor Quantum wanted to have happen again, from the sound of things.

“Before anyone gets too nervous, we do have a plan that we hope will keep things contained,” Lodestar announced. “The Wrexwren, like many warring cultures, pride themselves on their strength. Historically, they’ll allow a planet’s champion to battle their own to earn its salvation. We plan to invoke that, hopefully keeping the fighting entirely contained off-planet.”

“However, there is no guarantee this particular force will honor that tradition, or do so fairly,” Professor Quantum said, retaking control of his stage. “We must be prepared for the absolute worst we can imagine. Someone is coming to take this planet. From us, from you, from everyone you love. Many things are different across the stars, but conquest is constant. If we aren’t prepared, it will be brutal and bloody before you’ve even got your masks on.”

To Donald’s surprise, Lodestar actually nodded in agreement this time. “Hope for the best, brace for the worst. There’s no such thing as being too prepared. For our newer members, keep in mind that we won’t intentionally put you against something you can’t handle, but an invasion is a hectic time. We know little about the Wrexwren, their motives, or their potential allies. Trust your instincts. If something feels way out of your league, your first priority is communicating that back to base, not engagement. Information is going to be the name of the game.”

“Perhaps we should start at the beginning: expected arrival date.” Quorum had to be wearing a mic; there was no way that soft tone traveled so well on projection alone.

His words recentered Lodestar and Professor Quantum, perhaps one of the most essential tasks in all of the AHC. Professor Quantum nodded, then

made a motion. The screen behind him suddenly went black, or that was how it initially appeared. After a moment for his eyes to adjust, Donald realized he was looking at an image of stars. A flicker as the image changed, and now he could make out a small patch of Saturn's rings in the photo. Something else, too. A large ship that blended well with the blackness of space, unnatural in design. Too many angles and loops, it had design functions he couldn't even begin to guess at, for a biology he knew nothing about.

The third slide pulled a gasp from Donald, along with several others nearby. Now, they could see more ships, dozens in this one frame alone, with untold more outside the shot. Hearing the word "invasion" was one thing; seeing it stretched out through the vast void of space was an entirely different matter.

"Based on their speed, it is our estimation that the forces will arrive in less than a week's time. While we will of course monitor in case of acceleration, current predications have them entering within range of Earth on Saturday. I hope you all can appreciate the implications." Whether it was needed or not, Professor Quantum opted to go ahead and state the obvious, ensuring that everyone fully grasped the stakes of their situation.

"It means that if we do nothing, this will be humanity's last week in control of its own planet."



All the data was backing it up, ridiculous as the tip had been.

Wade was never one to turn down a solution, so long as he understood all the implications of using it. A random call to a guild-monitored line, leaving explicit information about the invading forces, was all but the literal definition of "suspicious." The thing was, that didn't make the tip incorrect.

People often thought of misinformation as untruths, and while there was certainly a fair bit of that in the mix, there was also more to it than that. On occasion, the right tactic involved giving out real information, but controlling *who* got it, and when. Move the pieces into position, predict their movements, and plot how to use them to the scheme's advantage.

Based on the message he'd gotten, the Wrexwren weren't coming to Earth with no idea of what they were stepping into. They knew the humans

had intel, and were planning to challenge them to a duel. They also knew the Earth had an undefeated defender, and they were still coming, which meant they had to think they possessed an effective counter. That part, Wade had been the most curious about, and as test after test returned the predicted results, it seemed he finally had an answer.

“The universe is a scary place, if things like that are just out there wandering around.” He looked over the digital image, constructed out of places the transmission vanished, like throwing paint around a hole to get a shape of the void. Without the message’s precise frequency to scan, it might have taken him weeks more to manage even this much. Seeing the picture on-screen, Wade felt a rare sense of foreboding.

This was no half-assed effort. Whoever was pulling the strings had accounted for nearly everything, even managing to stymie the guild’s power here and there. As much as Wade wanted to wait out the AHC, force them to return on bended knee, begging for even the slightest bit of aid, survival took precedence over grudges. The Wrexwren were coming hard, and so far seemed to be better prepared and informed than the humans they were up against.

The guild would need to be ready to do more than just scavenge and strike. Should the world truly be in peril, it wasn’t just the champions with a stake in its defending. His people would be ready, too, prepared to send a message to every alien, cape, and civilian that saw their handiwork.

Even monsters had the right to protect their home.

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## Chapter 91

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The flash in the sky was all she needed. Juan was asleep on the couch with Beth, and Rick had already locked himself in his room for the evening. Still, Janet paused by the door to scoop up the kitchen trash—less an excuse, more being productive with her time. Stepping out into the night, she shivered slightly. Fall was setting in more firmly; the night winds carried a crisp chill. Part of her wondered if she should have grabbed a jacket, though that might have looked odd to simply take out the trash.

Walking around to the side of her house, Janet popped open the large trash can and tossed her bag inside. Out of the corner of her eye, she caught movement coming from the driveway, a figure stepping into the floodlight's range, lighting up a whole section of yard. She'd have been so easy to overlook, had Janet not known the truth.

Adjusting her glasses slightly, the woman waited until the light flickered off, plunging them into darkness once more.

"I heard you wanted to talk."

"Talk?" Janet shoved the trash down harder, resisting the urge to punch and potentially break the bag. With her luck, she'd hit a wine bottle and fracture a knuckle—one more reminder of how human she was. "No, what I want is to be standing over the twisted remains of the people who did this, or living in a world where it never happened in the first place. What I'll settle for is getting some goddamn answers. You were in there the entire time: how *dare* you sit on your hands for a full day and make those children suffer."



Helen didn't rise to the anger. She simply nodded. "I know this is hard to believe, but being careful and going slow was my way of keeping them safe. The labyrinth had failsafes in case certain abilities were used, ones designed to target the kids. Until I knew what they were, I couldn't take the risk of accidentally causing the whole thing to explode."

"How convenient, that it just so happened so that one of the few times Lodestar can't use her speed is one where you're sealed inside a getaway with..." Janet forced herself to take a breath. Going off topic wouldn't help any of this. "Fine. I can accept that in your situation, with Ivan protecting the kids, caution would be the smarter move. My real question is what you intend to do about this moving forward."

"That's a perfectly fair concern," Helen replied. "To answer your question, I've only just started the ball rolling, so there aren't many details yet, but I'm putting together a new division of the Starscouts. Security-based, to ensure that nothing like that happens at one of our events ever again, or barring that, we have people to respond if it does."

Slamming the large trash can lid down, Janet wrinkled her nose at the last whiff of stink. "What a surprise, you went running to your followers. And now that the AHC has its hooks in, it's only a matter of time before they turn it into a recruiting pool."

"Happy to disappoint. This new division still isn't AHC-related." Helen was unfailingly calm, even cheery, despite the implied accusation Janet had just thrown. "Since the Starscouts are an organization open to humans and metas, we have quite a few of the latter who have graduated. I've been reaching out to old members, asking about their time and availability. There's lots of interest so far, but it's much too early to have many specifics in place. Just know that I take what happened this weekend seriously."

Janet wasn't sure why she'd expected anything different. Of course Helen already had a plan and an answer ready to go; not to mention found a way to get the personnel she needed without tapping the AHC. Given the role Helen filled in protecting the world, her efficiency and preparedness were technically positive traits, even if Janet did find them annoying.

"A good start for the Starscouts, but what about my kids?" Janet stepped away from the trash, onto the driveway, inadvertently setting off the floodlight once more. "I know who the target was, and why they chose that event to attack. There's no secret magic protecting their father's identity from getting out, or them from the fallout. If it's already started leaking,

then this was only the start of what's to come. Tell me you have a plan to keep them safe."

For a moment, Helen started forward, arms extending like she was reaching out to comfort Janet. That motion lasted for only a brief instant before she halted, just as the floodlight died once more. "I'm sorry, Janet. I know what you want to hear. You want to know your child will be safe, protected, and watched over no matter what. You want to be able to keep the worst of the world away, to drive it off, spare them so many horrible truths. That's why I'm sorry, because I can't give you that. Not even I can be everywhere at once."

Before Janet could begin her tirade, from which there would have been little reprieve, Helen continued, hurrying slightly. "What I *can* do is start by enrolling them in various AHC monitoring services, if you're comfortable with that. We'd set them up with some light surveillance and trackers, along with emergency response beacons they could push to alert us they are in imminent danger. Obviously, these would all be located here; your ex-husband's property is his own business."

"That's it? Your idea is to bug them?"

"I said it was the start," Helen corrected. "I'm happy to work with you to come up with more solutions."

To her credit, she did still have a polite smile fixed in place, but Janet doubted just how "happy" she'd really be if that offer was accepted. Not that it mattered. Hearing her proposal had only set Janet's determination all the more. "Pass."

"On which part?"

"All of it." Janet mimed forming the air into a ball, then tossed it over her shoulder into the closed trash can. "You think I'm giving the AHC even one door into their lives? It's just a matter of time until some cape with an old grudge or burning ambition decides to see how a legend's offspring hold up. Or hell, one might pull an Apollo and outright use them for hostages. My kids *will* have protection, but not from you."

Realization hit instantly. Young as she might look, Helen was concealing a wealth of experience. "As much as I get it—and I do—you understand what you'll be choosing, right? Ivan is not the norm in that organization. He's the leash they're all kept on. I understand the mistrust in the AHC, truly, and if you'd prefer, I can pick the capes assigned to them personally."

“Do... do you honestly think I’d trust *you*?” Janet was sincerely a bit shocked. She and Helen were on far from friendly, or even cordial, terms.

At long last, the veneer slipped, and Helen’s forehead pinched in frustration, causing her to run a thumb along the wrinkles that Janet knew would never set. “Outside of your—let me remind you—unfounded suspicions, yes, I would really like to think that if nothing else, you’d believe me when I say I’m trying to protect innocent children. I’ve got the track record to prove it.”

Forcing herself to stay in control, Janet took a few moments to breathe. She couldn’t afford to get overly heated. Much as she loathed it, there might very well come a day when Lodestar was the only cape in her kids’ corners. Janet knew she should play with at least a minimal amount of diplomacy until then.

“All right, perhaps that was a bit far. I’m standing by my decision, however. No AHC involvement. Maybe the guild won’t be as polished or as practiced in their protections, but they’ll know the stakes. They’ll understand just *who* they’re failing if anything happens to their charges. Besides, sooner or later, those two are going to learn the truth. Better they make some inroads with their eventual allies.”

Surprisingly, Helen gave another nod rather than keep debating. “Very well, then. It’s not the choice I’d have made, but you’re their mom. I won’t try to tell you what’s best for your family. All I can say is that if you ever do decide that we might be able to help, the door will be open so long as I’m there to hold it.”

The sentiment was a nice one, and probably the best place to end the conversation. Janet hadn’t gotten as much reassurance as she might have liked, but after a point, they would just be empty words. There was, however, one detail of the discussion that she refused to let lie. “I appreciate that, and I appreciate the help you’ve shown them so far. That said, let’s be clear: my suspicions were *not* unfounded.”

A loud, weary groan of a sigh escaped from Helen’s lungs. “I am several decades too old to stand in a driveway and fight about a boy. I’m sorry you think something went on between us, even though it didn’t. No secret affair, no tawdry messages. Ivan and I barely even talked when you two were married. He’d never have done that, and neither would I.”

“I know.” Janet was surprised to hear the words come from her own mouth. She’d realized all of that long ago, though giving the sentiment

words was another step entirely. “I know Ivan would never cheat, because I understand why he was here in the first place. It wasn’t an affair I suspected. It was the truth.”

“Janet, it’s been a long weekend, and I’ve still got a lot more work before the night is over. Can you maybe skip over being cryptic and just tell me what it is you think happened so I can set the record straight?”

“If that’s what you want,” Janet agreed. “I ‘think’ my ex-husband married me because I’d given birth to his son, which is admittedly the same reason I married him. He was a good husband—surprising, given his past—but Ivan is adept at throwing himself fully into things. So he became Ivan the father, Ivan the civilian, Ivan the manager. We had another child, built a life together, and over time, I thought we’d fallen in love. Then that day at the beach came. Horrific as it was, the image I can never seem to forget is what came after, when Lodestar arrived.”

There was genuine confusion on Helen’s face now, an expression Janet might have relished in other circumstances. As it was, her focus remained on getting to say her piece. “I know how Ivan looks at someone he loves. There’s a vulnerability that exists only in those instants. I caught it when he looked at our kids, or as a faraway glint on the rare occasions he’d open up about those he lost in the past. For a long time, I thought he just had a different look for me—one of affection and care, yet still not quite the same. And I was okay with that. You don’t wed someone with his baggage without expecting a few oddities. Until that day. Until you landed, racing over to comfort the man who’d just slaughtered an army. Until I saw the way he looked at you.”

“I cannot emphasize enough, nothing was going—”

“Do you think that makes it *better* for me?” Janet barely resisted the urge to yell, her hands forming into balls. “I get it. You did nothing wrong, as always. You were perfect, and moral, and continued to live at a standard no one else can touch, and I’m just the horrid monster of an ex who *dared* to want more than a hollow marriage. But he loved you. Loves you still. Don’t look me in the eye and pretend you don’t realize that.”

Some distance off, the sounds of a car’s brakes filled the silence of the night air. “Yes, Janet. I know how Ivan feels about me. That’s *why* we barely talked when you were together. Both of us understood the danger and avoided it. Because whatever passing affections he might have in my direction, this family is the most important thing in the world to him, as it

should be. And I promise you, Ivan never strayed, never even looked off the path. This emotion that you're angry about, I understand, but I'm not sure what more either of us could have done."

"While we're several years and a new, happy marriage past that point, some more honesty might have been helpful. I don't think Ivan is ever going to work past what he feels for you. However, if he'd been open about it, we could have at least tried." A brisk wind caught Janet, causing another shiver. Helen remained unbothered, of course. She lived in the same world as Ivan, filled with beings of incomprehensible power, a realm that mortals could only catch glimpses of.

"On that front, I truly don't know what to say. Getting Ivan to open up is beyond even the greatest of capes. Only he decides when to be vulnerable." Helen took a slight step back, turning on the floodlight once more. Head lifted, she was scanning the skies, preparing to leave.

Tempting as it was to let her go, Janet did have one last bit of curiosity to scratch, especially since answers were flowing. "You know, in all this time, I've only ever gotten to witness Ivan's side of things. That intentional avoiding of each other, was that purely for his sake?"

"Have a good night, Janet. I'll catch you around."

A few hops back out into the darkness, then suddenly, there was a flash of light and an empty driveway.

Janet headed back into the house; question more thoroughly answered than Helen might have intended. Nothing quite said inadvertent guilt like hightailing it out of a conversation at top speed.

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## Chapter 92

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Halfway through her Monday morning wake-up routine, Tori paused to wonder if she even actually had to go in to the office. So far, they'd generally given her a few days off after each life-shaking traumatic event, but a corporation's goodwill could only stretch so far. Then again, she did know the boss, and the guy who owned the whole damn shebang, so perhaps she was receiving more generous time to recover than most. Toothbrush still hanging from her mouth, Tori popped open her phone, a text from Ivan already waiting.

"No office today, but there's still work to do. Meet me outside your building at our usual start time."

Interesting. Tori tossed the phone down and slowly resumed her brushing. No telling for sure what today's activities would entail, though she could make a few general guesses on the subject matter. After a night of sleep and a few thousand actual calories, she was feeling far less wiped, but the new secret she'd uncovered still lay heavy on her mind. Tori was extremely thankful Helen had explained that it was impossible for her to slip up; at least she didn't have to worry about some wrong word or turn of phrase giving away what she knew.

A few solid raps on her door were all the warning she got before Beverly shoved it open. "Hey, you almost ready in here? Chloe got up early to cook you a 'welcome home' breakfast, and I am not facing that alone."

"That was sure... kind of her." Tori had never quite gotten her flames hot enough to manage turning something solid into total ash, which would

have made disposal of the goods far easier. Perhaps an invention to consider, once her suit was fully repaired.

“At least you can stall until it’s time for your office job,” Beverly said, marking one of the few times she’d expressed jealousy for Tori’s corporate-cog status. “Speaking of, since my more distracting roommate was gone all weekend, I made a lot of headway on our project. Couldn’t sleep after you got home and hit the lab, so I stayed up and got pretty close to being done. By tonight, I should have my part ready for the prototype.”

“So soon?” Tori would have expected turnaround like that from herself, which was to say a person with a poor work-life balance and tendency to hurl herself into projects. Beverly was far more reasonable in her passions. Even if she was incredibly skilled, she still must have put in a lot of time to already be near finished.

Beverly affected her best haughty expression, one that actually sat quite well on her finely sculpted face. “You’re not the only one capable of knuckling down when the occasion demands.” Her face softened, a sliver of weariness cracking through. “Plus, there’s been all the stuff with my family reaching out—having something to work on made for a great distraction. After this, I might build us a new dining room table.”

“Don’t go overcommitting too fast. If the prototype goes well, we’re definitely going to need more.” Tori stepped into her bathroom, partially to do one last appearance check, and also to buy more time until she had to head into the kitchen. The woman staring back at Tori was one she’d never have imagined possible. Brown suit, long skirt, hair back, stud earrings, and sensible shoes. She was so... boring, and Tori felt a strange swell of pride in her heart at that notion. This was a woman who lived a normal life, worked a boring job, and had the dullest of secrets. Building this image had taken time and effort, not to mention quite a bit of guidance from Ivan.

If everything went well, Tori wouldn’t be able to keep playing this angle for much longer. She wouldn’t be revealing any heavy truths to the world, but the new role required different features to succeed. That was getting ahead of herself, though. They still had to finish the prototype, impress Wade, and start the ball rolling on production. Nevertheless, Tori took her time examining that reflection, more than just to delay eating Chloe’s food.

At the rate her life had been changing, by this time next year, she might have three heads and a tail. Best to appreciate the moment while she was still in it. If Tori had taken no other lesson in her life, she knew that nothing

—no time, no phase, no joy—lasted forever. Sooner or later, everything came to end.

Without warning, Chloe's raised voice rang out from the kitchen. "Hey you two, does anyone have an allergy to pimento cheese? I found a waffle recipe online that suggested using it in the batter and thought that sounded fun."

Tori stepped out of her bathroom, locking terrified eyes with Beverly, who reflected her expression nearly as well as the actual mirror had. Hiding was no longer viable; they had to get proactive.

Wordlessly, Tori put up her fist, and Beverly did the same. They each shook the closed hand three times, then reformed it into the finger-symbol of paper, scissors, or rock. Tori won the first match with a last-second scissors, but Beverly took the second thanks a well-timed rock. The final bout was neck-and-neck, yet Tori's own rock ultimately claimed victory.

"You know what? I think I *am* allergic to that," Beverly called, pausing only to shoot Tori a dirty look. Tori accepted the gaze, along her prize of not having to remember a new fake allergy.

Such were the spoils of victory.



"Excuse me, sir, can I help you?"

Ivan looked up from his phone to see the two figures he'd already clocked approaching standing nearby. The blond was big—not just raw muscle, either. He moved like someone who actually used his body rather than only building it. Next to him was a shorter fellow with brown hair and a lean frame. Given what he knew about Tori's living situation, Ivan had a hunch on who these might be. Still, muscles did not a meta make. It was possible they were normal ruffians planning a robbery. Although, early in the morning, with their arms full of groceries, would certainly be a departure from the mugging norms.

"Appreciate it, but I'm just waiting for someone." Instantly, both men's faces tightened. They were either on guard patrol or were up to shady activities of their own. Clearly, this wasn't a good answer. Deciding to part with slightly more information, Ivan added, "My niece lives here."



The shorter one—Tachyonic, if Ivan was getting this right—stepped forward. “Sorry to say this, but we’ve had a few incidents surrounding some residents as of late. Perhaps there’s somewhere more comfortable you can wait.”

“My answer is a polite, firm no.” Ivan looked back down at his phone, effectively dismissing them both. “I’m standing on a public sidewalk, not inside the building where you may or may not reside. Since I don’t see any badges on display, this doesn’t seem to be a discussion of loitering coming from an officer of the law. Unless you two are both secretly superheroes, we’re all civilians, and I’ve got no reason to move.”

It was a tad mean, coming so close to calling them out, but they needed to learn to split their identities better. These sorts of discussions had to happen when they were in costume. Without that authority, they just seemed like interlopers bothering strangers, at best.

To their credit, both were flustered, but neither one lost themselves entirely. Instead, the one who had to be Agent Quantum gave a knowing grin, then walked over to the building’s brick exterior and placed his back against it. “He’s right. We’ve got no authority to make this gentleman move. But we do have just as much right to stand out here as him, making use of the public sidewalk.”

Smarter than the physique indicated, not that Ivan was too surprised. Professor Quantum’s attachment to his legacy was legendary among capes and villains alike; the man protected his brand better than an entire PR firm could manage. For him to pass on the mantle, even if only part of his name, was a tremendous vote of confidence in the one who’d be carrying it. Agent Quantum wouldn’t have the title if he were merely some hulking bruiser. To earn that, there was no telling what sorts of tests he’d had to endure, let alone pass. Ivan had a hunch that once this kid started showing what he could really do, they’d be in for quite the show. Possibly even a real challenge.

Tachyonic moved slowly—a detail that very nearly caused Ivan to chuckle—stepping over to his friend’s side, his eyes never leaving Ivan. He paid them no mind, putting the final touches on his email before hitting send. With that, his schedule had been effectively cleared for the week. Waking up to find he’d been temporarily reassigned, by the head office no doubt, to a special research project had been momentarily confusing, until he noticed the message from Wade. It was vague, as all monitorable guild

correspondence tended to be, but the gist came through. Something was up, and while he'd get the details later that day, all indications seemed that it was serious. Wade didn't go around butting into Ivan's schedule willy-nilly; he knew that sort of invasion was only acceptable under extremely necessary conditions.

With work done, Ivan glanced down, noting that the shopping bags were largely filled with various coffees and caffeinated beverages, along with a few sandwich-shaped bundles letting out wisps of steam. Whether it was boredom or simply his office small talk kicking into gear, Ivan found the words leaving his mouth before he'd thought to give them leave.

"Late night?"

That earned a scowl from Tachyonic, yet Agent Quantum nodded without hesitation. "Never a dull moment in Ridge City."

Ivan made a noise in his throat that *could* have been agreement, or simple acknowledgment that the words had been properly heard. It was one of his favorite tools for weathering office meetings, allowing him to handle most questions tossed in his direction without getting bogged down in needless details.

"What about you, mister? Out burning the midnight oil?"

"No, I had a very long, trying weekend. A night of heavy sleep was well-earned." Ivan felt that was true, even though he hadn't gotten one; instead, he'd wasted most of the night digging for any leads on their mystery trapper, only to come up empty. Whoever had thrown that orb was hiding themselves well. Same for Cobblord—no luck, not that Ivan really expected to succeed. He'd never had much talent for locating people. Ivan's skills kicked in once he had a target.

"Sorry to hear that. Hopefully the week ahead will treat you better." Agent Quantum's face twitched, only for a moment, yet in it, Ivan saw his realization. This would not be a normal week—based on Wade's estimates, at least. Seemed like the capes might have finally started letting their people know what was coming.

Ivan gave a shallow nod. "It will certainly be an interesting one."

The slam of a nearby door lifted all their eyes to the same location, which was how they all ended up staring at Tori as she strolled into the afternoon light. He could hear the capes tensing, practically feel it at this proximity. If they thought he was here to do harm, then she would be the

chief target for such aggressions. They were waiting to see if he would make a move.

Neither, however, was fully braced for Tori.

“Ivan? What the hell? I thought you meant we’d meet at the office.”

“We’re heading somewhere else, so this was faster. Special company research project. We’ve been moved over to it all week.”

“As long as it’s not more quarterly reviews, I can manage.” Seeming to notice the capes for the first time, Tori’s eyebrows scrunched together.

“Kyle, Austin, why are you guys standing on the sidewalk?”

The flabbergasted look on both Austin and Kyle’s faces was such a spectacle, Ivan wished he had a way to snap covert photos. Their gaze went from him to Tori, then back again, as they began to process the implied connection.

“Wait, is this guy your uncle?” Kyle asked, putting a fine point on the issue.

“There’s some cousins and marriages in the equation, but yeah, he’s pretty much been Uncle Ivan since we met.” The proud gleam in Tori’s eye made it impossible to miss how well she’d threaded the needle of truth with her carefully chosen words.

After a few more head-turns—too many; he was giving into his speed—Kyle fully faced Ivan. “Sorry for bothering you. We had to be sure you weren’t a danger.”

With great effort, Tori almost managed to change the harsh bark of laughter that tore from her into a coughing fit, albeit not very convincingly. “You guys were sweating my uncle? What did you think Ivan was going to do, build an organizational spreadsheet of doom?”

Not a bad recovery, at least. Better they think the joke was how comically non-dangerous he was than sniff out anything near the truth.

Austin took a more diplomatic approach, offering Ivan a hand to shake. “I apologize for the inconvenience, if we caused any.”

“Not for the act itself?” Ivan accepted the hand, even as he posed the question.

“No, sir. One of our residents has been targeted or endangered multiple times in short succession. I’m glad you were telling the truth; however, you easily might not have been. I’m not sorry for trying to protect this place or the people in it, and I won’t do you the disservice of lying about it.”

It didn't happen often. In fact, Ivan would say for a long time that it had happened never. On rare occasions, however, he'd get a feeling. Part hunch, part experience, potentially part cosmic connection to the greater forces of the universe. Gripping Austin's hand, looking into the young man's clear eyes, Ivan could sense the barest bit of that old feeling rising from within. A sensation like he was touching his opposite, coupled with recognition of the spirit brimming out from those eyes.

This kid was dangerous. Not in the ways so many of the others feared—raw strength that could be turned against them in force. No, what he had was more insidious, and ineffable. It radiated off of him, that genuine, earnest attitude that made people want to trust. Want to believe. A cape who could lift a mountain was an easy force to predict and contain; one who could inspire others to heroism had a far further reaching impact.

The world before and after Lodestar's arrival was proof enough of that.

Thankfully, Austin was young, and Ivan felt himself questioning the assessment almost as soon as the handshake ended. He had potential, the raw makings were there, but there was still a lot of growing to do before Agent Quantum became a major threat. Ivan would have to keep an eye on him, though. Today's rookies were tomorrow's veterans; the guild would be ready for conflict long before Agent Quantum was.

"I suppose there are worse neighbors than ones who keep an eye on suspicious characters," Ivan conceded.

"Tori's not just our neighbor, she's our friend," Austin corrected. "We'll do our best not to let anything happen to her."

It was a very nice sentiment, largely undercut by their inability to stop any of the attacks she'd suffered so far, not that Ivan could really blame them for those. Someone had been outmaneuvering both the guild and the AHC—expecting four rookies to outperform that went past ridiculous into outright silliness.

Tori made her way over, giving quick high-fives and farewells to Austin and Kyle, then followed Ivan as he led her to the car. Behind them, the heroic duo scooped up their groceries, finally heading indoors after their unexpected delay. Once Tori and Ivan were in the car, they remained silent, waiting until the capes were inside and fully out of view.

"What's up? Is this another day off thanks to the weekend's craziness? 'Cause if so, I think I'd like to head to my lab."

“Not this time. Something is happening, big enough that there’s no communications about it going out. We need to head to the guild and see what’s going on,” Ivan explained.

“Damn, now you’ve got me all curious.” Tori buckled her safety belt and adjusted the car’s air vent, lowering the output by half. “Also, I could have used a guild car. I know the weekend was nuts, but you didn’t have to drive all the way out here.”

Putting the vehicle in gear, Ivan pointed it toward the highway and steeled his courage. There was still a chance to back out, knowledge which forced his tongue to move, lest fear leave it locked in silence. “I picked you up because I thought you might have questions about... well, I’ll let you tell me. Given who one of those topics might be about, we can’t have the talk on guild property, and not many civilian locations are secure enough to discuss something so sensitive.”

Tightening his wheel-grip slightly, Ivan set his will and finished the statement. “This drive is in case you wanted to ask me about Lodestar.”

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## Chapter 93

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It was so shocking, Ren had to blink and rub his eyes, despite their above-human vision. Sure enough, this was neither a hallucination nor imagined, which meant the next most likely explanations were a meta with body-possession, copying, or illusion-based abilities. Long shots, sure, but the other choice was to believe what he was seeing.

Donald Moss had beaten him to the gym.

Given the looks of things, not by a tremendous amount; the freckled, pale face of his friend was red, but not yet slick with sweat as he pushed on the weight machine working his chest. For a moment, Ren lingered at the edge of the room, still barely filled on a Monday morning, searching his mind. Had Donald ever even come here on his own before, let alone been first? Not that Ren could recall; it certainly would have stuck out in his memory.

Walking with more grace and precision than he could have dreamed of after his initial shift, Ren approached from the side, waiting until Donald let the bars fall slack and leaned against the seat, panting from effort. How hard had he been going already?

“Vanity, or ambition?”

“Huh?” Donald’s face roughly matched the words: bleary-eyed from the combination of a late night and an early morning, along with the surprise arrival of his friend. Ren hadn’t slept great either, not after what they’d learned, but he’d plainly done better between the two of them.

“That’s not a maintenance workout, and it’s not you going through the motions to appease me. This is the first time I’ve seen you in here with

actual drive. Usually, that means someone either decided to sculpt their body, aka vanity, or they found a goal to work for, which I simplified to ambition.”

A moment passed before Donald managed to sort the words and put together a proper response. “Fear, I guess.” He tried to shove the machine’s bars forward, struggling in vain; he’d gone too hard already, and now the current weight was beyond him. “Or maybe frustration? Every time I feel like we’re making headway in this job, something reminds me how weak I am. Not being able to help Tori, not being able to stop Hephaestus, and then last night’s announcement... there’s an invasion coming. People are going to be looking to me to do something about it, trusting me to keep them safe. This isn’t busting muggers or doing patrols, Ren. This is war from the stars, and I’m a guy who turns video game items temporarily real. I couldn’t sleep, and doing nothing was worse, so I came here.”

Sometimes, there were perks to an empty gym, such as unexpected honesty. Given how Donald had opened up, Ren could offer nothing less than his own truth. “I get it. It’s really terrifying, when you realize we’re part of the line that has to hold. I’m not sure it scares me in the same way, but I do get the drive that kicks in when you feel yourself up against a wall and want to be better.”

“Maybe once I get half as strong as you, the fear will ease up a bit,” Donald joked.

“You think I’m not as afraid because I’m tougher?” Ren looked around, taking note of the few other bodies present and their current distance. He was pretty sure none of them had meta-hearing, but sometimes, it had to be risked. “Donald, I’m less scared because this job... this is *all* I have. My life, my dreams, even my body got taken away when that meta-storm struck. One day, you might take those talents and do something else, find another way to help, move on to a new phase of life. This, right here, is the best it gets for something like me: still able to help, to make a difference, to matter. There’s no leaving that behind. I’ll be in this work until the day I fail. It’s easier not to be afraid when I already know this job will kill me. It’s just a question of how much good I can do before it does.”

Donald reached out and grabbed the machine’s bars once more, though rather than trying to push, he used his already weary arms to pull himself up, out of the seat. Fully standing, he turned to face his friend in the eye. “Dude, that is *messed* up.”

“Pardon?” Ren’s inhuman face twisted around, making his version of surprise.

“This is all you have? All you’re good for? To *hell* with that. What we do here matters a lot, but you’re not some battery to be used up and cast aside for it. I am sorry, man. I didn’t realize how hard things still were for you. Been too caught up in my own dumb shit to notice. But the AHC can’t be your whole life, and I’m going to help you be okay with that, whatever route it takes. We can even start hunting for a way to reverse the changes. Just because the AHC lacks one doesn’t make it impossible.”

A night of sleepless anxiety, unknown time sweating at the gym, and Donald’s mental state hadn’t improved one bit. Less than a minute of having a friend’s problem to focus on, and suddenly he was newly alert and engaged. It was strange. Cyber Geek clearly felt unsure in a position of leadership, likely because he didn’t have the same talent for combat that some on the team did. Yet in terms of valuing his people, listening to them and considering how they felt, Donald was head and shoulders above countless coaches Ren had suffered through. The guy was like a brace on the other side of a wall: easy to miss, but the support made everything he touched sturdier.

“Thanks. Maybe I need to hear that sometimes. That said, we should table that idea until after the attempted invasion. This seems like a good week to stay focused on the job.”

While Donald’s face didn’t look thrilled, he nodded all the same. “Can’t argue well against that. Guess it’s time to climb back into this contraption.”

Ren snagged his arm, hooking a clawed thumb over to the free weight. “Forget it. Now that you’ve got a spotter, we’re doing the bench. If you’re really here to work, I’ll show you how to safely get stronger.”

With an exaggerated bow, Donald moved from the machine. “Part of me already knows I’ll regret this, but lead the way.”



“For the most part, I think I’ve got the basics figured out. She’s the Starscout contact you kept mentioning, so after that night with Haywood, you went to see Helen, who pitched leading the cluster as penance. Ostensibly, Lodestar is also there because putting Fornax in charge of



impressionable youths would rub people who don't know you the wrong way. The rest sort of falls into place from there, but one thing I haven't figured out yet is why I'm in this, too."

Ivan had remained silent as Tori considered the opportunity and put together a response, only speaking once the pause in Tori's words stretched long enough to be sure it implied a question. "That was Helen's idea. She knew you were at Haywood's office somehow—the AHC has their tricks, as well—and wanted you to get the same lesson: actions have consequences."

Had Ivan dropped that bomb before the first Starscout meeting, Tori might have had a hard time wrapping her head around that as motivation. Even now, her first instinct was to assume it was a trick, part of a larger plan to learn more about her abilities and whether or not she was a threat. But after the weekend she'd spent at Helen's side, Tori understood. Lodestar wanted her to see that there were consequences because she was still hoping to turn Tori away from the path she was on. That thought raised a sudden memory, which created quite the new question.

"Did you know she pitched the idea of me switching over to the capes?"

"Not specifically, but I'm also unsurprised, if that's what you're wondering. Teams change. While usually more tend to flow in our direction than the other, there is precedence. We'd have a few securities put in place, some mental blocks to keep you from accidentally letting anything slip; otherwise, it's a fairly simple process for where you are. Someone like Johnny or Pod Person might have more trouble, but you're only just starting out. Not even an official criminal record yet."

Considering that, Tori could see how it would be viable, yet for all the work joining the guild had taken, could leaving really be that easy? "Guess I'm just surprised you don't put up more of a fight."

Staring in the rearview for several moments, Ivan suddenly changed lanes, then returned to normal speed. "Given your passion for technology, I'm sure you've heard of Tyranny, the inventor who rules over her own country of Indroga."

"Sure. Possibly the greatest meta mind out there, only no one can be sure because Indroga has a massively strict immigration and visitation policy, so we've never gotten a good look at her full potential. She doesn't even allow capes to set foot on Indroga soil."

“Almost,” Ivan corrected. “She has one exception: only Lodestar is allowed on Indroga. I had occasion to ask her why that was, once. Her answer is very fitting for this current, and quite a few subsequent, questions. Best as I recall, she said, ‘A ruler must have absolute power over their domain. All that occurs within it occurs with their permission. I cannot stop Lodestar from coming, nor do I think any bureaucracy would halt her if she knew there were people in need. Therefore, since she may arrive regardless, and I am Indroga’s ruler, she *must* be arriving with my permission.’”

Not a hard story to see the parallels in, especially given her question. When one was facing an overwhelming force, it was often a matter of choosing battles. Yes, the guild could dig in and be shitty if one of their own opted to start doing good, but what would that gain them? Ire from the capes, and a member ripe for turning to treachery. And since it wouldn’t look very good to have the AHC dictating terms, deciding it was a mutual policy allowed the guild to save internal face.

“At some point, I definitely want to circle back and hear more about you actually talking to Tyranny.”

“I’ll save you the time: she was cordial enough, but our conversation centered largely on dealing with capes, many of whom aren’t even around anymore. She and Wade had a far more productive discussion that day, if you can ever get him to part with specifics.” Another change of lanes, this time paired with acceleration.

Weird driving and inventor tangents aside, Tori tried to focus in on anything she wondered specifically regarding Helen’s secret. Other conversations could continue; this one had a shelf-life. Since Ivan had been so forthcoming, and Tori wasn’t one to beat around a bush, she decided to just go all in on the obvious.

“Do you love Lodestar?”

“Whether they know it or not, everyone loves Lodestar, in the same way every blade of grass loves the sun. She has single-handedly saved the entire world several times, including all life on it. It’s coded into all nature to seek and love the things that keep you alive.”

“I’ve never seen a blade of grass and the sun spend ten minutes making flirty small talk over a bin full of paper mâché,” Tori countered. “You’re going to tell me there’s nothing there?”

“Not nothing, no.” Ivan was checking his mirrors more frequently, and Tori was starting to do the same. Something was off, even if he didn’t want

to address it openly. “Respect, friendship, even trust. There’s a tremendous amount of history between Helen and me. Some things are bound to be built atop such a rich foundation.”

It was a nice spiel, the kind that almost made one overlook the fact that Ivan had never actually come out and denied Tori’s accusation. She decided to let it go for now. The point wasn’t to make Ivan sweat with a discussion about feelings, it was to answer her questions and get a clear head.

“She already knew who I was, so I guess nothing has changed in that department. You two have your own thing. Pretty sure I don’t want to dig much deeper into that can of worms. I guess my main question left would be... is she for real? The concern, the caring, the way she sees things: I have a hard time believing it’s not at least partially an act, but I never saw anything other than sincerity from her. Now that I know her power conceals her identity, I wanted to know if there was a chance that was fake, too.”

“Hmm.” Ivan’s hands drummed the wheel, stopping only once to suddenly jerk the car around a slowed van in front of them rather than reduce speed. “Technically, it is possible that this is one more aspect of the abilities, though it’s highly unlikely. I believe I’ve mentioned that Lodestars are consistent across all the universes we’ve scanned, and part of it is that they’re always trying to do good. Not always Helen’s exact brand, that shifts with who holds the power, but they are, at minimum, attempting to work on the side of right. For them all to be fake, the power would have to have no failings in any world we’ve checked, and then you’d have to ask yourself why? What’s the point of pretending to be good if you spend your life saving the world anyway, and at that point, is it even still pretending?”

“I get it, I get it. Morality is hard to gauge in any real sense, but so far as we know, her actions consistently match her attitude.” Tori rubbed her left temple, aware the day would end in a headache, yet fighting it off for as long as she could. “Guess this is why we stick to smashing skulls instead of saving worlds.”

The exit came fast, but Ivan was ready, jerking the car off the highway, on track to the country club they’d be teleporting out of. “Actually, I did save a world once. Sort of. Not this one... got summoned by mistake, but the experience was more fulfilling than one might expect.”

“Wait, what? Forget Lodestar—the hell happened there?”

“Story for another time, I’m afraid. We’re being followed, and I wasn’t able to shake them.”

For an instant, Tori's skin went cold. More attacks, more chaos, more madness, and she'd barely had time to even partially recover from the last. Then, slowly, warmth returned as she remembered that this was no scouting trip stocked with innocent children. To her knowledge, there was only one other meta who could be a real threat to the villain seated next to her, and Lodestar wouldn't need a crappy sedan to follow them in. This was a pothole in their road, not a gaping chasm to leap.

"Should we floor it?"

"Scraping them from our heels was ideal, but the time for that has passed." Ivan's face darkened, and Tori quickly remembered that he'd also had a very shitty weekend, and that currently, they had no clue which of them was the target being tailed.

"Running is for prey. Our kind lay ambushes."

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## Chapter 94

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Their tantrum reached a fever pitch as the camera equipment was torn open, electronic guts dropped roughly onto the gravel. On the television screen, Tori watched as the country club security roughly grabbed one of the photographers that had been on their tail as he lunged for the camera, slamming him to the ground and beginning to administer zip ties.

“This is really legal?” It wasn’t that she didn’t enjoy watching a pair of parasites being pulled from their car and having their belongings carelessly searched, but it did seem the sort of thing that might come with consequences.

“They drove past multiple signs informing them they were entering private property, with no trespassing permitted and all vehicles subject to search. Given that they were tailing you, a person who has endured multiple attacks in a very short time, it’s natural we assume them to be criminals as well and thoroughly check their belongings for hidden weapons or explosives. Resisting the process can only lead to them being detained until the police can arrive to scoop up this refuse.” Ivan managed a straightforward tone, despite the not-so-subtle smirk inching along his face.

“I’m just sorry you’re still having to deal with this. I’d hoped the fervor would fade quickly. Seems they’re either doggedly determined or news you were at the Starscout incident has started to leak.” Though they’d done their best to hide the names of those involved, when the bulk of the witnesses were young children, some were going to make slips when asked the right question.

The second paparazzi attempted to make a run, bolting to where one of the guards was yanking out what looked to be an extremely expensive video camera. He grabbed for the equipment, managing to actually pull it away, thanks to the element of surprise. It fared far worse seconds later, as it went flying from his arms, shattering while its owner fell to the ground shuddering, body filled with electrical current. Only once the guard he'd robbed stopped holding down the trigger on his tazer did the twitching at last relent.

"Believe it or not, this kind of works for me. I've got some big plans coming up, and still being part of the public consciousness is in my favor for them. Speaking of, I need to talk with Wade soon. Think he'll be around base today?" With the show winding down, Tori turned from the monitors to the rest of the security room.

It wasn't the actual security wing of this building, rather the mundane one that had existed in its original incarnation. Closed-camera TVs lining the walls, stacks of electronics poorly organized and maintained, even a guard with drooping eyes leaning back in his chair, keeping a sleepy watch on everything happening. Seeing as this employee, like the vast majority of others, was secretly robotic, how open his eyes were didn't actually impact his capacity to do the job. It was simply a small touch of detail. That level of care into every project was part of why Tori admired Doctor Mechaniacal's skills in the first place.

"Wade will definitely be here, though you might have trouble catching him free." Ivan glanced down at his watch, noting that they'd spent a tad longer than they should have enjoying the show. "I've got a meeting with him and the other councilors momentarily, after which, I'll bring you up to speed. While I'm there, I'll see about your meeting... just don't expect anything today."

"Perfect for me. Only looking to get something on the books again. I'm not quite ready either." Tori's mind jumped back to her prototype, now nearly complete. Much as she wanted her suit repaired, she'd also have to make time to properly polish that up. One generally didn't get multiple pitches to multi-billion-dollar corporations, not even with secret villain connections.

Together, they walked through the resort, into the secured teleportation chamber, and crossed untold miles in a single flash. Once at the guild, Tori opted to go grab a breakfast she wouldn't have to pretend to eat while

covertly tossing out the window, while Ivan headed up to his meeting—past the residences, the utility rooms, the lounges, all the way to the new Councilors’ Chambers.

He was, in a rare anomaly, the last to arrive. Morgana looked tanner since they’d last seen one another—evidently, she was spending a lot of time at the new guild with its ample sunshine. Gork and Xelas were seated next to one another, the latter swiping a hand through the air as she browsed unseen screens. Arcanicus was holding what Ivan deemed to easily be the largest mug of coffee he’d ever seen, his bleary eyes betraying why. Stasis was clad in a surfing outfit, her post-meeting plans very apparent, whereas Wade himself looked as if he was going into the Indigo Technologies offices, clad in tan slacks and a crisp shirt.

It was rare to see Wade like that while in these halls. Knowing him, it meant he’d gotten some new piece of information in his civilian outfit and had been too excited to even consider changing, or probably showering. Although it was a habit that could make Wade hard to room with, it also meant he was good at finding answers, devoting himself entirely to whatever question was currently occupying his brain.

The outfit was one tip-off, the look in his eyes another. It wasn’t often that Ivan saw that expression, but when he did, it meant things were about to get extremely complicated, and equally as dangerous.

“Good, we can finally start,” Wade said. “Ivan, please shut the door. There’s a lot we need to talk about.”



Zerle Salvryn’s subganwum sacks swelled with pleasure as the orb filled his screen. Blue and green, quite picturesque—if one went in for that sort of thing. He held no particular passion for the aesthetics. What tickled his yerkle were the readings they’d taken from that captured Grzzniltan ship. One of his clawed fingers ran along a panel of dark metal, turning the screen from a picture to a display of that lovely, lucrative data.

Oceans of water, huge tracks of land, an ore-rich core, and billions of lesser lifeforms to serve or feed upon as their talents dictated. A civilization nearing the verge of galactic travel, ripe for the plucking. The Grzzniltans were turned away by a few mere guardians, cowards that they were. Earth

would not be so fortunate when it faced the Wrexwren fleet moving toward them.

Two of Zerle Salvrin's eyes kept watch on the communications channel, always waiting for a fresh transmission. Their mysterious Earth informant wasn't the most constant information source, yet what they'd provided thus far had proved valuable. Without the initial broadcast, Zerle Salvrin might never have sent a crew to intercept that Grzzniltan vessel in the first place, leaving this gorgeous celestial pulvin completely unflugged. It was also thanks to their informant that the Wrexwren knew Earth had a special defense, a seemingly unbeatable force.

Changing the screen once more, Zerle Salvrin checked the dispersal of plasma his ships were carefully leaking. One couldn't tame, control, or even direct creatures like that which was following in their wake. All they knew was hunger: perfect machines of function, to Zerle Salvrin's reasoning. The only way to use one was to lead it to the planned destination and turn it into someone else's problem. Whatever supposedly unstoppable defenses the planet had, this would neutralize them nicely.

In a way, Zerle Salvrin was glad this planet had some capacity to put up a fight. His crew had faced far too little adversity in recent conquests, enemies falling like the shards of eslewright that rained down on the Wrexwren's desolate homeworld. Lack of challenge would make them soft. He hoped the Earth would manage to put up enough resistance to demand some effort, though in truth, he expected little. A planet so coddled and cared for would cause most of its inhabitants to lose their edge. Once their champions were broken, the world was essentially done.

Not long to wait, now. They were on course to reach Earth at the appointed moment. They could have arrived weeks early, but the messages were quite specific about the timing, claiming that there was preparation to do. Zerle Salvrin didn't entirely trust this source; however, he also didn't want to alert it to that fact by ignoring the agreed upon plans. They would play along while the source proved to be useful. Once that function lessened, circumstances could be reevaluated. After all, it wasn't as if Zerle Salvrin had told their contact the actual number of Wrexwren ships in the approaching fleet.

By the time Earth realized it was in danger, the conquest would already be done.





In his life, Ivan had seen a great many things. He'd gone briefly to the stars, wandered other worlds, and walked many realms hidden within their own plane. Yet even with his wealth of experience, the sight on-screen caused his heart to hammer. This wasn't just big, wasn't just bad; it was raw, absolute destruction.

Ivan could recognize his metaphorical kin when he saw them. An invasion was one thing—it had certain goals and plans, most of which centered on keeping the planet intact overall as it was being overtaken. This was different. These aliens weren't planning to leave more than a used-up husk behind. They didn't care about losing resources in the name of efficiency. The Wrexwren weren't coming to take over Earth, they wanted to strip it down to the studs.

"Given the new situation, it's safe to say the AHC are not prepared for what they'll actually be facing." Wade was still somehow calm, despite the rundown he'd just delivered on the threats currently en route to Earth.

"Most of our people are already planning to be on the ground in the event Wrexwren troops start landing—nothing changes much on that front. The bigger question is what we do about this new intel. While I recognize that we and the AHC are not on our best terms, protecting the planet we live on generally supersedes such momentary grudges."

"You want to tip them off?" Morgana proposed.

"Fuck that. After what Apollo pulled? It'd be good for the AHC to get publicly pantsed again." Xelas, despite her harsh words, didn't sound particularly passionate in her pettiness. "I'm on board with helping keep Earth safe, but we're not their spies or messengers. Let's not start acting like it."

Wade changed the screen, revealing a series of images showing various terrains with specific sections marked. "I'm with Xelas on that front. If they want our help, then they'll at least have to acknowledge it happened. Currently, we have several space-capable weapons locked on the approaching fleet. Attacking preemptively is still an option—break their formation and make them panic. But it risks them turning tail, only to come back better prepared, and again, the AHC can spin things as they see fit. Alternatively, we could sit on our weapons until the ships arrive, then add

our firepower to the fray. We won't have the advantage of surprise, however, so active defenses will cut down on how well the attacks work."

It was forming, no matter how Ivan wished it wouldn't: the path to victory, the way ahead, that determination to come out on top that had helped him survive his eighteen straight years of hell. There was a plan coming together, spurred on in no small part by Janet's words still ringing through his mind. "The surprise is obviously for Lodestar. They're hoping to take away Earth's superhero before any sort of duel could officially start. Professor Quantum would never put himself in a position that vulnerable, so he won't step up. Quorum might, but he's also the weakest of the three in combat. They'll either send in someone tough enough to buy time, or give up on the duel entirely, focusing on the armies themselves."

"Tracks with their historical tactics." Gork nodded her large gray head solemnly as she agreed. Her people lived far, far below the planet's surface, meaning that this invasion wouldn't impact them for quite some time. But in a planetary-wide looting, sooner or later, every stone got turned over.

"Seems Ivan and I had a similar train of thought," Wade added. Another slide clicked over, this one showing tech-specs that went sailing right over Ivan's head, but that garnered a whistle from Xelas. "I've reached out to every extraterrestrial contact we have and begun work on a welcome gift for our visitors. Assuming it's completed in time, I would still need proximity to use it. If we were to send our own envoy, along with a champion, it would be a perfect distraction while I put our new tool to work."

Loud slurping from Arcanicus and his oversized mug momentarily broke the tension. He glared right back at several of the looks he received. "What? Does anyone actually think I'm the one getting tapped for this? It's obviously a task for Xelas or Gork—possibly Morgana, if these things have blood."

"I'd prefer to have Xelas with me—should cut down on how long we need." Wade pointedly didn't look at Ivan as he continued. "Whoever we take should be able to withstand some damage. We don't have a firm idea of how strong the Wrexwren are, but it's safe to assume we'll get one of their best, considering the stakes."

When Ivan stood, the room went silent. Now Wade was looking in his direction, old friends staring at one another, trying to figure out what the other was thinking. "There's only one choice. We need someone who can

endure, can hurt, can survive against nearly any odds. Remember, technically, we're still betting the planet on this fight. Makes sense to try and win."

"Are you sure about this?" Wade asked. "Working as Pseudonym in the shadows is one thing—everyone in the world will be watching when the invasion comes. The AHC will absolutely have some sort of video gear with them; they'd never let PR like this pass undocumented. Depending on what happens and how much is caught, this is a fight where the identity could be easily compromised."

"Then it's a good thing I wasn't proposing Pseudonym take them on." Ivan shut his eyes, not trusting them to remain human in that moment. What Janet had said was true. People weren't scared of him anymore, not of some dusty old monster from the past. They were getting bold enough to come for him, and his children. White-hot rage spiked in Ivan, and he didn't cool it down so much as set it to the side. Fury had ample uses in the right moments, and it seemed he'd be getting such a chance very soon. Because if the world thought they didn't need to be afraid, then he'd just have to remind them why that terror had existed in the first place.

"If they decide to try to step around Lodestar, then the bastards can face Fornax instead."

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## Chapter 95

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Tori found the guild in a lively state upon her arrival. Since the move, she'd been seeing her fellow villains sporadically; it wasn't quite the default clubhouse the old location had been. Yet today, as she helped herself to a breakfast burrito, it was impossible not to notice all the faces, both new and familiar, dotting the halls. Heading to grab some coffee, she found herself in line behind a pair she knew quite well.

"France? You really want to wait in France? Just because they always go for the Eiffel Tower at some point in the movies doesn't mean the real ones bother with landmarks." Johnny Three Dicks rapped a knuckle against Thuggernaut's sizable shoulder, the closest Johnny could get to reaching his head. "You want the biggest population centers you can find. Absolutely going to be a target, and if you don't find any cool alien stuff, there's always looting the normal stores in the chaos."

"You use whatever tactics suit your needs best," Thuggernaut replied. "I've been wanting to visit a good open-air market for weeks. This is a chance to go early and knock out two errands in one trip."

Johnny grumbled, but Tori would bet that when the dust settled, they'd both end up in France. For as much as Johnny talked, he was smart enough to stay near his much larger, more intimidating friend.

Since she saw an opening in the conversation, Tori coughed loudly before asking, "Did someone say aliens? Are the Grzzniltans coming back?"

Thuggernaut and Johnny both turned, expressions softening when they recognized who was speaking. Johnny's sour mood quickly shifted into a

mischievous grin. “Well, well, if it isn’t Pseudonym’s old apprentice. Decided to take a break from being the damsel du jour?”

“I really fucking hope so.” Tori’s response came out a bit more honest than she intended, so she hurried onward. “Next thing I invent might be a giant firebomb I keep with me at all times. Be a fun surprise for the dumbfucks that try to grab me next.” Actually, that wasn’t a half-bad idea—she made a mental note to see how viable it was. “Anyway, what was that about aliens?”

While Johnny feigned a confused look, Thuggernaut merely nodded. “Given the potential danger of the outing, only the more experienced members were initially brought up to speed, but I expect that to change soon. The guild has been tracking several alien ships heading toward Earth. We suspect there’s an invasion afoot.”

The shock on Tori’s face was both evident, and completely ignored by Johnny as he took the chance to reinvigorate their prior debate. “That’s right, a whole swarm of new marks bringing their favorite goodies for us to snatch. Which is why we should go bigger. No telling how long before they wise up and flee. Have to grab as much as we can while it’s here.”

“Hang on... are you guys kidding?” Much as Tori wanted to hope for that outcome, both seemed serious, or as serious as a man named Johnny Three Dicks could manage.

“Not in the slightest.” Finally, Johnny seemed to register the uncertain fear in Tori’s face, his own smile growing wider in response. “Oh my, are you worried? How fun! It’s been so long, I’ve kind of forgotten how that feels. Pulse racing? Starting to get the sweats?”

“Enough.” Thuggernaut’s voice was calm, but brooked no objections as he silenced his friend. “Sorry. Sometimes, after you’ve been in this world for so long, you forget what it’s like to be new. Johnny is right in one regard, though, you really don’t need to worry. Ever since we first learned aliens existed, both the AHC and the guild have prepared for these possibilities. It’s not even Earth’s first attempted takeover.”

He was right. Tori had read up on the prior attempts for herself here and there. Forcibly, she took control of the terror that had reared its head, shoving it aside until she could think more clearly. Her view had been that of a civilian, if not an outright human, fearful of this newly discovered threat. She’d reacted like prey rather than recognizing what else the aliens

represented: opportunity. As a predator, what she could see was something slithering in, unprepared for the native beasts already lying in wait.

“Is there a betting pool for how long before they go screaming off into the night?” Tori asked.

“Oooh, look at our optimist here.” Johnny stepped forward, the coffee machine finally opening up as he jammed his mug underneath. “The Wrexwren making a successful escape is currently one of the long shot bets, so if you’d like to toss some money on it, I can give you decent odds.”

Tempting, though it was always better to have things spelled out to the letter with Johnny. “What defines a successful escape?”

“Retreat with greater than fifty percent of the original forces.” Thuggernaut didn’t even have to mentally dig around—he had that tidbit ready to go, a subtle tip-off that perhaps Johnny had been trying to coax others toward this wager, as well. “In this case, we’ll be counting whatever they land with.”

“There’s also decent money to be made in the twenty-five to fifty percent range,” Johnny added. He moved over to the sugar station, grabbing a handful of various artificial sweetener packets seemingly at random. “Once you get lower than that, we leave the long shot area, and you’ll see a steep drop in payout.”

While Thuggernaut took his turn at the coffee machine, Tori flipped the situation around in her head. At the end of the day, it was a question of who she thought was stronger: the Earth and its metas, or this extraterrestrial force coming toward them. It was always possible they were outgunned, but if that truly were the case, if these things could overtake people like Lodestar and Fornax, then there was no fight to be had. Earth would be wiped out, likely in a day, and no amount of Tori’s fretting would change that. Power at those levels was beyond her ability to deal with, currently.

“Any advice for someone who’s apparently about to go through her first invasion?” It seemed prudent to get some guidance from those who’d been there before, and her selection in that range was deeply limited.

Surprisingly, Johnny’s expression shifted, turning almost serious. “Be on your guard, and with people you trust. Us being collectively stronger doesn’t mean each of us can defeat each of them. Use every advantage, and take nothing for granted. Don’t ruin the fun by making us have a funeral after.”

His gravity was jarring, enough to remind Tori that these stakes were still life and death. Having powers and the guild didn't change that; they just gave her a better chance to survive. "I'll talk to Glyph, Pest Control, and Bahamut. Guessing they'll be in the same boat, and we can watch out for one another."

"A fine idea," Johnny agreed, instantly softening back to his usual countenance. "The next step would be to determine where you want to wait out the invasion. Somewhere cool and hip—say, the middle of downtown New York—or out in a big, open area with a giant metal art display."

"Your lack of appreciation for art doesn't remove its inherent value." Thuggernaut and Johnny were back in their fight, absentmindedly wandering away from the machine as Tori filled her mug.

As if her week hadn't already been slammed enough, now she had a potential alien invasion to worry about. Part of her wondered why Ivan hadn't told her yet, before realizing that she'd probably stumbled on the very reason they were here today. At least if Wade didn't have time to meet, she would definitely know not to take it personally.

Even for a genius like Doctor Mechaniacal, countering an invasion was one hell of a side project.



Ridge City Grinders was *slammed*. Chloe had no idea if it was the new Electric Conga Cappuccino they were shilling that month or just an especially caffeine-demanding Monday, but her morning had rapidly turned into a blur of grinding, pouring, and handling customers. Most were coping all right with the excessive line, others less so.

"Still waiting on that large latte." The watch he was tapping against the counter cost easily more than any car Chloe had owned, and he definitely knew its value. From suit to shoes, the whole outfit was meant to convey wealth and authority, personality traits that had evidently drifted into his capacity for polite waiting, as well.

Glorious as it would have been to work some small errors into the order, that would only delay things further; he was absolutely the type to kick up a fuss. Putting the final touches on the foam, Chloe set the drink down

directly in front of him, motioning to the accessories as she did. “Thank you for your patience, sir. Sugar is on the table, as are lids and straws.”

“Lids,” he scoffed, grabbing the drink roughly. “I’m not a child or an imbecile. I think I can handle—”

It was truly perfect. Mid-sentence, the cup seemed to suddenly slip in his hand, tipping over toward him. All down the silk shirt and tailored suit the near-boiling coffee ran, drawing screams of both pain and horror from him as he suddenly leapt back. The coffee cup, now all but empty, clattered to the ground in front of him, one final nail in the coffin of his humiliation.

Despite knowing better, Chloe couldn’t resist. “There are also napkins, in case you have a spill.”

The laughter was quick and contagious, rippling outward like a mocking stone dropped in a lake. There was barely enough time to see the rage and shame in his eyes before he bolted from the shop.

“That guy is definitely going to beat an intern before lunch is over.”

That voice was familiar, though unexpected here. Chloe glanced up and realized that Ike and Ellie were in line, the former still chuckling to himself.

“He seems like at least the type to call a manager. If he complains, let us know. We can attest that you were nothing but professional,” Ellie added.

“Thanks, but there’s cameras all over since the Ridge City Riots. I’m sure we’ve got footage that shows him spilling on himself.” Even as the words left Chloe’s mouth, she found herself doubting them. The way he’d lost control of his cup was very strange, almost like someone had moved it while in his grip, causing the container to go tumbling over. “That is what they’ll see, right?”

Ike met her gaze without hesitation, offering little more than a shrug. “Sure what it looked like to me. Certainly what the dude deserved, right?”

At his side, Ellie leaned slightly over Ike, turning suspicious. “I suppose, in that case, we could call it karma. Karma that in no way should be emboldened by this and start doing it frequently.”

“I doubt it will be an issue. Seems to only happen when people are dicks to someone I like.”

“You don’t like anyone,” Ellie pointed out.

“I like Chloe. She shoots straight and doesn’t take bullshit. More people had that attitude, I might not be such a misanthrope.” Ike punctuated the statement with a wink, a gesture that Chloe might have found less endearing several minutes prior.



“Says a man who refuses to just admit what he really feels,” Chloe replied.

That earned an actual laugh from Ike, along with a snap of the fingers. “See what I mean? Even after that, she refuses to let me skate. Great stuff.”

“Sorry about... all of this.” Ellie looked back to the sizable line still stretching out behind them, and the other baristas working hard to clear it. “We should probably order and get out of your hair.”

“Hope you’ve still got some warm fuzzies in our direction, because this order is massive.” To his credit, Ike wasn’t overselling the list he pulled from his pocket; it filled up the front and back of a large sheet of paper.

Looking it over, Chloe noted that since the drinks were built over function rather than form, she could make the bulk of it in batches. There were a *lot* of high-potency drinks on the list, though, stuff generally only ordered by the true addicts, like Tori.

“I can put this together, just going to take a minute. You must be bracing for one hell of an all-nighter.”

There was unquestionably a look exchanged between Ellie and Ike, one that Chloe pointedly chose not to follow up on. Whatever secrets they had were probably AHC-related, and Chloe was more than happy being on the outside of that loop. The more she saw of both sides of the cape-villain coin, the more joy she found in her normal life and job. Ultimately, it was Ellie who spoke, likely not trusting Ike to avoid dropping some manner of hint.

“It’s safe to say that a lot of people won’t be getting much sleep this week.”



By the time Ivan found her, Tori had finished breakfast, done quite a bit of chatting with other guild members, and generally gotten a good grasp of what was heading their direction. An invasion was coming, enough that the guild was expecting troops to land and planning to lie in wait for them. Nobody seemed especially scared about Earth actually losing, which aligned well with Tori’s own deductions. Either their champions could handle it, or the planet would be crushed. At those higher tiers of power, there was no middle ground.

“Done?” Ivan asked. He didn’t sit at the small table where she was clacking away on a tablet, an indication that this would be a walk-and-talk conversation.

“Depends. Do you mean with eating, or with finding out about the invasion you didn’t bother bringing me in on?”

“Both, but mostly the latter. I assumed this would be faster than me explaining, and then you digging around behind my back anyway.” Evidently, Ivan took her response to be confirmation, as his brisk pace resumed.

Tori briefly scrambled, throwing the tablet under her arm as she hopped off the stool and gave chase, catching up to him shortly. “You still could have gotten me up to speed before now. Seems like the whole guild except me had the heads up.”

“All newer members of the guild were left out of that loop. None of you have faced a substantial enough threat to have an accurate combat rating, and we don’t have time to get you trained up before this invasion arrives.” Ivan’s words hesitated, even as his feet continued without pause. “Perhaps some part of me also imagined that keeping you in the dark would hold you apart from the danger such an invasion represents.”

“Gave up on that idea?” Tori found the notion hard to imagine. Ivan sure didn’t seem like he’d gotten *less* protective after the weekend’s incident.

“In a way. I’ve realized that my power alone is not enough to protect the people I care for. Had help not been with us for the Starscout incident, the outcome could have been very different. You, alone, might have been killed by those traps and challenges, or we may have lost some of the children in our care. All of which represents a failing on my part.”

They came to a stop in front of an elevator. Ivan led her inside. Once there, he tapped a sequence into the buttons, sending the mechanism diagonally, rather than up and down. “I haven’t been nurturing your talents the way a mentor should. I taught you the code and survival first, and that was right, but since then, I was content to let you slowly find your own path. My hope was that you would reject this life, find a way back to normalcy. This weekend showed me the folly of that mindset. Unless you are powerful enough to survive our world, you’ll never have a chance to leave it behind.”

“Hang on, there. I don’t necessarily want to go whole hog into the guild,” Tori protested. “I like finding my own path. It’s the happiest I’ve been in a long time.”

“A journey you are welcome to continue. My concern is not the search for what to do with your life, but rather making sure you live long enough to complete it.” The elevator came to a stop, and Ivan punched in another set of numbers. This time, rather than moving, the doors opened to reveal a new room.

Tori’s breath caught in her throat at the sight of it. Gleaming metal, flashing screens, a wall stuffed with one strangely shaped tool after another. Tentatively, she stepped out, surveying her surroundings. “Ivan, this is a lab. Not a basement lair, not a retrofitted garage, a *laboratory*.” Her voice was caught somewhere between confusion and longing, not daring to approach even the edges of hope.

“Correction: it is *your* laboratory, rented for the next month, though the coming week is the most vital part of that. I expect to see Hephaestus’s armor back in working condition at least a day before the first wave of invasion is predicted to arrive.”

Given the equipment present, that would be a relatively simple task. So much of the tedium from her work could be automated or simplified with all of this at her fingertips. There might even be time for an upgrade or two, though she was hesitant to put in something untested before a potential fight. Still, the situation nagged at Tori; she didn’t trust when anything came too easily.

“Not that I don’t appreciate you getting me some nice digs, but mind if I ask why? Do you really expect me to get in danger during the invasion?”

“I do not,” Ivan told her. “Nor did I expect you to be taken from the street, or my daughter to end up stuck in a labyrinth. The time for being taken by surprise is at an end. From now on, we are the ones who deliver the shock. Next time something happens, we’ll be prepared. You’ll have your suit, and I’ll be ready to do what’s necessary.”

Tori could still remember how it felt being in there, watching Lodestar work, realizing how outclassed she was. If she’d had her suit, things would have been different. Tori would have had more options, could have contributed to the fight and gotten them home faster. Much scarier, however, was wondering how it would have gone if Helen hadn’t been around. Tori didn’t want to need the capes. She had to be capable of

handling this insane life on her own. Although, a little help at the start was something she could make peace with.

“Got it. Work starts as soon as I haul over my gear. After the month, do I need to make arrangements with Doctor Mechanical to keep paying?”

Ivan merely shrugged. “You’ll have to ask him. He seemed to think you might wish for different facilities after that, depending on how your enterprise goes. Your meeting with Wade is set for Wednesday afternoon, by the way.”

That tracked. If they were starting something new together, then she might want a more public facility. A concern for later down the line; right now, Tori was staring down a pair of very imposing deadlines. She had a few days to get the prototype finished, and a couple more after that to ensure her meta-suit was in tip-top running condition.

With a gleeful crack of her knuckles, Tori set off to explore her new lab. It was time to get to work.

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## Chapter 96

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He could still hear panting from that inhuman mouth, no matter how hard he ran. It was supposed to be a simple stickup—that couple had the look of a pair with more money than caution. But no sooner had the knife come into view than the creature dropped down from above. Had it been hiding on the rooftops, waiting for a juicy victim? There was no telling. New meta-animals popped up same as humans, each with their own powers and dangers.

All he'd known was that, when it roared, his legs moved. Bolting him from the scene so fast he'd dropped his weapon, racing with all he had, and making what felt like zero progress. Every turn, every street, it was on him. He dared not slow down enough to turn and look, but there were times he could swear there was hot breath splashing across the back of his neck. There was no thought, only running.

Until he hit the wall. In his defense, it was an unexpected obstacle, as this alley was supposed to open up into a wide street. Instead, a frozen blockade smashed against his body, sending him sprawling. There were walls of the same material on either side; only the way he'd come was still open. Spinning around, the would-be mugger prepared to keep running, just to be reminded of why he was fleeing in the first place.

Standing there, backlit by the streetlights, he could finally get a good view of his pursuer. Thick muscles, scales, even a tail: this was no single meta-animal, more like what a mad scientist would create with only a zoo for parts. That didn't make it any less terrifying as it stepped forward, low rumbling growl rising from deep within.

“I give up! I surrender! Somebody—capes, cops, help! He’s going to eat me!”

A slight wince in the approaching monster, before that growl turned into a rough, annoyed voice. “You’re in luck, buddy. I’m a superhero with the AHC, so you know what that means.”

A big, broad smile revealed a mouth stuffed full of fangs, each somehow larger and sharper than the one before. “It means they only let me eat the ones who don’t play nice.”



As Medley wrapped up their latest catch with help from Cold Shoulder, Cyber Geek and Hat Trick were seated on a bench, scrolling their AHC-issued phones, checking for any assignment updates. Direct communication was useful in battle, but for assignment coordination, it was hard to beat the convenience of screens and GPS.

“Sounds good. Yeah, we’ll be back at the incident point. Meet us when extraction has this one removed.” Cyber Geek finished his remote chat with Cold Shoulder, who was keeping an eye on things as Medley’s backup. Splitting the team was essential when it came to drawing out these sorts of criminals—few things were lured without bait—but he still disliked how it left them vulnerable. Not even Medley was allowed to run off on his own. Muggers could just as easily have meta abilities, too.

“What’s the plan now?” Hat Trick asked. She was, for the most part, unrecognizable as her superhero self, clad in a bright dress too summery for the cooling weather, along with a large designer coat. Hidden within its depths were her hat, wand, and a few other trinkets in case things took a turn for the dire, but on the outside, she looked to be nothing more than a normal woman on a nighttime stroll.

In a rare display of fashion, Cyber Geek matched her well, clad in slacks and a button-down more reminiscent of his cubicle days than his current position. He’d been dressed in a few high-end accessories as well, or at least excellent reproductions, since the AHC didn’t seem especially concerned about loaning them out. Together, the duo were playing the part of a couple lost in their affection for one another, blind enough to the world that they’d wandered into a place where dangerous people liked to hunt.

“Probably time to pack in for this operation. Getting so late we won’t be believable soon. Besides, I’ve seen you hurting in those heels, and I’m ready to get in my real uniform, too.”

“For the record, it’s not the heels,” Hat Trick said. “I can walk in heels when I have to, even if they aren’t my favorite. It’s these designer ones. I don’t think they were built for women with all their toes, or even a centimeter of extra ankle.”

She leaned against Cyber Geek’s shoulder as her hands worked to loosen the tight shoe-straps visibly digging into her flesh. When one latch finally gave, the whole thing seemed to pop, falling away in a series of snaps and straps he could never have hoped to reconstruct.

“Ohhhhhh, there it is. That’s the good stuff. Don’t suppose you’ve got any shoe-based items I could use?”

“Wish my power worked that way.” It would have been incredible, to outfit his team with an endless array of weapons and armor from across the world of gaming. Unfortunately, the items were only real for him. Losing contact with an item was no issue, yet when he tried to give one away, it quickly dissolved back into numbers and sparks. That was something they’d learned in the earliest of experiments, and while it was fun to dream of his power evolving that way over time, so far, there were no indications his ability had any potential to grow in that direction.

Shifting position, yet somehow still with her shoulder against him, Hat Trick released the second shoe with far less effort, scooping it up into her lap before digging around in her pocket. From the coat’s depths, she produced her wand, a single black rod with crisp white tips on either end: a magician’s wand, to go with the kit she’d purchased that had imbued her abilities. It was strange to imagine gaining powers that way, especially given that Cyber Geek had been nearly deep-fried when obtaining his. The sources of meta-abilities were nearly as varied as the powers themselves—one more reason to always be prepared for the unexpected.

“Not to worry. I’ve been working on something. Zesto-Chango-Outfit-Rearrangeo!” Hat Trick waved the wand as she spoke, ending with a flourish that tapped the tip of it against her left shoe’s heel. A burst of smoke exploded from the footwear, causing both undercover capes to cough and wave their hands.

Once the cloud cleared, Cyber Geek spotted a new pair of shoes waiting where the heels had been. Black, shiny, and made for the stage, Hat Trick

had managed to change her designer footwear into the standard shoe of a tuxedo-clad magician.

“Drat. Been working on getting them cuter, but everything comes out like I’m about to step on a stage.” Hooking one of the shoes, Hat Trick slipped it easily onto her foot. “They do fit perfectly, though, and are surprisingly comfortable. I’d make you some, if they didn’t all come out in my size.”

“That’s still amazing.” Cyber Geek shook his head, part of him wanting to look around for where the original shoes had been hidden. Magic was fascinating. It played by its own rules even among the metas who wielded it. Evidently, that also made it harder to control than some other abilities, though Hat Trick had been making incredible strides. “I remember when you first started and didn’t even use the wand.”

“Well, I wouldn’t rely on it in a life-or-death situation, but it has proven to be a handy little tool,” Hat Trick admitted.

Watching her put on the second shiny shoe, a new thought occurred to Cyber Geek. “Wait, don’t you have to turn those back in? I signed out all of my fancy clothes and was warned to bring them back.”

“I’m sure Faldica will be mad at me, but maybe if the AHC would start keeping a wider array of sizes on hand for this, I wouldn’t have to transform them midway through the night.”

Cyber Geek wasn’t entirely sure what an appropriate reaction to that would be. While it was true that Hat Trick didn’t necessarily have the same frame many female superheroes aspired to, she never seemed bothered by the difference. Since the complaint didn’t seem to be coming from a place of insecurity, rather one of annoyance, she probably wasn’t looking for reassurance about her appearance, even if he had trusted himself to express such a sentiment without bumbling things into awkwardness, which he did not.

“I’ll see what I can file about equipment issues. Having the right gear for us to do the job is part of the AHC’s responsibility. If they can make outfits and tech for all the different types of metas we work with, it’s not unreasonable to expect them to have shoes that fit.”

Hat Trick flushed slightly, easy to spot on the pale skin between her freckles. “You don’t have to kick up a fuss on my account.”

“Someone on my team isn’t getting what they need to do their job safely. If that’s not worth kicking up a fuss over, what is?”



Her smile was swift and sudden, shining under the streetlight without warning, so earnest that Cyber Geek found himself looking away after only a few moments. “I suppose I can’t argue with our leader on that front. Maybe wait until next week, though. Given what’s coming, I think the AHC has bigger issues to focus on at the moment.”

It was a thought he’d been trying, and failing, to avoid since the announcement. Only a few days left, and the world would potentially be at war with outside invaders. They knew the fight was coming and were prepared, yet still Cyber Geek’s guts twisted when he dwelled on the nearing conflict. With people like Lodestar and Professor Quantum on their side, he had a feeling the Earth would come out victorious overall. But wars didn’t just impact the people at the top of the spectrum. There were billions of innocent people who could be swept up in the battle just as easily.

In essence, Cyber Geek wasn’t afraid of losing, so much as he was afraid of how much would be lost. That was why his downtime had been largely spent training with Medley. The big capes would take care of the major threats, but it would be on them to keep things safe on the streets. He wanted to be ready this time, or at least as ready as he could be.

“You make a fair point. We can take care of the complaint next week. Until then, we’ll stick to costumed patrols.”

“Uh huh. Just don’t go getting any ideas about signing us up for one tomorrow. Some of us need that occasional bit of downtime.” Hat Trick paused, looking around the empty night. “Speaking of, do you have any plans for your day off? I know Wednesdays aren’t exactly hopping, but it feels like we should all make good use of it. You know... just in case.”

Just in case they lost. Just in case the aliens were stronger than expected. It was a lot scarier, being on this side of the curtain, realizing how many threats he’d been able to live ignorant of by being a civilian. For all the stress it caused, Cyber Geek was pretty sure he preferred it this way. The Ridge City Riots had come out of nowhere, taking him entirely by surprise. A little warning wasn’t so bad, in comparison. Especially if it gave him the chance to tackle things he’d been putting off.

“Another excellent point,” Cyber Geek agreed. He was scanning the area, so he missed Hat Trick’s face lighting up, along with the slight opening of her mouth, as if to speak, before his own response continued. “In fact, there’s an appointment for coffee I’m well overdue for. Seems like a good reason to finally make that happen.”

He turned back to find Hat Trick wearing a soft grin, with the barest hint of lip caught by one of her upper teeth. “Sounds like a nice idea. I think I’ll make the trip to see some family during the day, probably spend that night hanging with the team.”

“I bet they’ll be overjoyed to—” Cyber Geek trailed off as his phone began to flash, signaling a new alert. “Crap, looks like we’ve got some sort of meta-bear sighted, and it’s near... okay, that has to be a joke.”

Checking her own phone, Hat Trick barely suppressed a giggle. “Nope, I’m seeing the same report. Ten feet tall, looks like a bear that’s been rolled in spines, and currently attacking a production center for the BingleBuzzle Honey Corporation out in Brigsby, Utah. Be honest, if we get there, what do you think the odds are it will be wearing a bright red shirt?”

“The real question is if it will *only* be wearing the red shirt,” Cyber Geek added. “This one will make Medley happy, if nothing else. He’s been complaining that he never gets a real workout in the field lately.”

“You think a mere ten feet of bear can challenge our boy?”

“No idea, but I’m willing to sit on the sidelines and cheer as we find out.” Cyber Geek tapped the alert on his phone, instantly connecting his earpiece with the appropriate AHC communications facilitator.

“Confirming, this is Cyber Geek. We’re already in Utah on patrols and can take the bear, just need rapid transport for my team.”

Heavy footsteps from nearby signaled to both of them that they weren’t alone any longer. Thanks to Medley’s sizable shadow, the mystery of who was nearing was quickly solved, as he and Cold Shoulder soon stepped into easy view. “Tell me we’ve got something interesting this time. I’m tired of slow-chasing these robbers into the iceboxes.”

“It does get tedious,” Cold Shoulder agreed.

“How about a giant meta-bear attacking a honey factory—that grab you as tedious?” Hat Trick countered.

“Grabs me as you having a laugh.” After a moment of looking at Hat Trick’s expression, Cold Shoulder lifted an eyebrow. “You’re serious?”

“The report is serious. We’ll see for ourselves soon enough if the situation is.” Cyber Geek had barely finished the words when there was a flash of light nearby.

Standing silently was a man clad in a simple, white cotton outfit. Catching a ride with an AHC asset was rarely the same experience twice—they had too many movement-metas aiding a huge staff in itself, so the odds

of getting the same transportations frequently were slim. Upon arrival, this fellow motioned to the area around him, wordlessly indicating that proximity was required.

They headed toward him, Cyber Geek angling himself to arrive next to Medley. “How you holding up? Need a rest or anything?”

“After that chase? I don’t even consider myself warmed up, let alone gassed.” Medley’s claws flexed as he spoke, and his tail gave itself a good long stretch before settling back into position.

“Looks like someone is excited for a good brawl.”

“Are you kidding? A fight that might be an actual challenge, and not against another human or sentient creature I’ve got to hold back against? I’m not just excited, I can *bear-ly* contain myself.”

There was just enough time for Cyber Geek to give his friend a dirty look before the light flashed once more, leaving nothing more than an empty street and a single silver buckle that had broken off a designer shoe.

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## Chapter 97

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“I don’t give a shit what Gram-Gram says, you need to trust me.” Beverly had spent a great deal of effort post-confluence gaining control of her new transforming powers. That was why she was able to still be in human form, not even dragon enough to accidentally shatter the phone in her hand, as the argument dragged on.

“Cancel the damn trip. This isn’t the weekend for apple-picking. Be near the house, and have weapons at the ready.” She paused, listening to the same reply she’d been getting for nearly an hour. “Because you’ll be glad you did! Goddamn it, Ambrose, just keep the fucking family home this weekend. Please.”

A crisp knock on the front door pulled Beverly from her pacing, giving her a welcome exit to this frustrating exchange. “I’ve got someone at the door. We can talk later, but I expect you to get the ball rolling on this. I’m not playing around.”

With that, she ended the call, walking over to open the door and reveal Kyle, along with Ellie. Both looked weary, though knowing what was secretly on the horizon for their weekend, Beverly hardly found that surprising. The AHC was likely running itself ragged in preparation for the looming threat.

Since she was supposed to know none of that, having only been brought into the loop by Tori on Monday, Beverly stuck with a simple, noncommittal greeting. “Hey you two, what’s shaking?”

“We were hoping to speak with Tori, if she’s around,” Ellie opened. “There’s some... scheduling issues with this coming weekend. Might be

hard to properly guard her, so we wanted to, if she was okay with it, maybe get a little heads up on where she was planning to be.”

Given that they’d be handling an invasion, it was actually nice to see that the AHC still took the time to properly cover the people they were actively guarding. There was no chance in hell Tori would go for it, but whatever tactics she used to keep this team at arm’s length were hers alone to figure out.

“You’d have to ask Tori herself on that one, and she’s not currently around.” Beverly checked the clock on the wall, realizing she’d gotten so lost in arguing that she hadn’t even noticed the hour change. “It’s Wednesday, so she’s got a meeting, and I think she mentioned something about grabbing coffee after. That means she’ll either be back here or pestering Chloe at Ridge City Grinders. If that doesn’t pan out, you could always just use the phone.”

Kyle shook his head. “This seems more like a face-to-face conversation. Tori hasn’t exactly been shy about liking her privacy, and I don’t want to seem like we’re prying. We’ve still got some of the week left, but if I’m near the coffee place, I’ll pop in.”

He started to turn away, but Ellie remained, staring at Beverly closely. “Actually... you don’t have any big plans this weekend, right?”

The conflict was obvious, looking at it, knowing all that Beverly did. Ellie wanted to warn her friend about the upcoming invasion, to make sure Beverly was safe. Except word wasn’t supposed to leak out—the AHC would absolutely want to control that narrative, even if only to minimize panic. So now, Ellie was suddenly stuck, the desire to protect weighed against her trust in the AHC that silence was right for now. Perhaps another villain would have taken some pleasure in seeing a cape discomfited, even momentarily, but Beverly felt the pain far too keenly. In a way, it was exactly what she’d just been dealing with regarding her own family.

“Who, me? I have a glorious weekend planned out. Laying around, streaming movies, catching up on work, ordering far too decadent of food—really just two days of indulgence. Sort of a mini-vacation to recharge the batteries. I’ll be shocked if I leave this apartment, though you’re welcome to come join if work is slow. Kyle, that extends to you too, and the other boys, but I warn you now that I will not tolerate any insubordination on film selection. The rom-coms are happening.”

Relief flooded Ellie's face—they *really* had to get better about hiding stuff—as she nodded enthusiastically. “That sounds amazing. I may just take you up on that after... after my work is done.” It was a near miss, but Ellie recovered in time, albeit not quite quickly enough to save Kyle from wearing a very nervous expression.

He managed to give a polite wave as they departed. “Have a good day. And please let Tori know we stopped by, in case we don't spot her at the coffee shop.”

“Take your time heading over,” Beverly advised. “She's probably still got a fair bit of meeting left to go.”



Wade examined the item from all angles, running his fingers along the seams, getting close to the pattern, even sniffing one particular section of faux-leather. This went on for ten full minutes as Tori sat, patiently waiting. Having a master of the craft evaluate her work would have been worth it alone, but this was the chance for so much more. If they'd done well enough, this could be the start of something brand new, a place outside of villainy where she could succeed.

“Okay, walk me through it.” That was all the guidance Wade gave as he set the prototype back down on the table.

Rising from her chair, Tori approached and scooped up the device, hanging it carefully from her arm. Nearby was a small area with several cardboard dummies. Each had been made up with a classic ruffian face, drawn scruff and painted-on scars unique enough to make Tori wonder if she'd found Wade's secret hobby. Their purpose for today was to serve as stand-ins for real crooks, though Tori wouldn't necessarily have objected to warm bodies for such a test. There was time enough for that after more R&D, she supposed.

“As you can see, from the exterior, this appears to be nothing more than a tasteful purse, and does indeed function as one. For the majority of its owner's life, it could do that job without ever being anything more. But let's say one night I can't catch a car and wind up walking through a particularly dangerous area. Suddenly, I am accosted on all sides by would-be thieves. What's a damsel to do?”

Tori strode over to the cardboard cutouts, mentally replacing them with her actual kidnappers. This device wasn't just marketing bullshit. It mattered to her. Feeling helpless, trapped, unable to fight back—Tori wanted to kick those fears in the fucking teeth. Not just for her, either. For anyone who picked up one of these purses. As an inventor, this was her pride and passion, a chance to actually *do* something the world couldn't ignore. So it had to work, and not just against cardboard. Tori had to feel safe even when mentally facing down a crew of kidnapping metas, because that might very well be what one of these devices went up against.

"The answer is simple. You run your finger along the silver section woven into the handle. There's a specific path to make sure it isn't triggered by accident, but if you're trying, it's easy to do. After that..." Rather than explain, Tori simply activated the trigger. A small piece on the purse's front parted, revealing a spray nozzle that doused the cutouts in green mist. The cardboard was, unsurprisingly, not effected by the spray; however, Wade picked up his phone and began to peruse some sort of display.

"Fascinating. This liquid is unstable, but the effects are quite potent. How many shots per cartridge?"

Waiting until the nozzle was fully spent and the front section had resealed, Tori moved the purse back to her side, tapping the base. "Three per purse, to start. Beverly is working on moving toward a more modular design, something where we could swap out the exteriors and cartridges easily. If it works, you can technically just sell the one purse, and then have separate skins to change out, like phone cases."

They waited a bit longer, until Wade's phone chirped a loud beep at him. "It seems the effects of the spray have now ended. Are there any secondary effects or other features you wish to show?"

Up until that moment, Tori had been feeling pretty good about their work; however, she'd also been hoping for a tad more enthusiasm. Trying to stay optimistic, she shook her head. "That's the basics for now. It's easier to build from here after getting your input than to press forward and have to go back for redesigns."

"A wise choice, as there is still much work to be done," Wade agreed. Not the most encouraging, but if they were continuing work, then it meant the project would still be alive. "Tori, what you have created is quite useful, will certainly have a market, and would never reach shelves in its current

incarnation. The design itself is quite nice. What it fails to account for is the potential ramifications.”

Wade motioned to the purse, still hanging from Tori’s arm. “That weapon is capable of temporarily neutralizing metas with actual power, which makes it useful and dangerous. No sooner would it hit store shelves than we’d see them wielded for robberies, slowing or weakening capes, and all manner of general disarray.”

“So... it’s a no?”

“Certainly not. There’s profit to be made here,” Wade corrected. “This, Tori, is where your business education begins. You already know how to build powerful weapons and tools. What you haven’t yet experienced is bringing a new product to market without tipping the scales of power or stepping on the wrong toes. This is what you came to me for.”

He extended a hand, reaching for the purse. “May I?”

Tori handed it over, watching as Wade’s pale hands turned the prototype around several more times. “If I were the creator of such a tool, my first step would be identifying what pieces of the technology were unique, as those are the ones to protect more stringently. Here, everything you’ve used is fairly straightforward, with the exception of that liquid. Therefore, our main concern is keeping it proprietary, stopping these delivery mechanisms from being used illegally, and ensuring that the cartridges can’t be utilized by another device.”

“The cartridges are already built to be tamperproof. I’m sure together, we can get them secure. I really don’t think anyone can synthesize this liquid; it’s spliced-together insanity, and does not play well with other chemicals or equipment. They’d melt a lab and give their eyes a chemical burn before making much progress.”

“You’ll forgive me if I take a few attempts myself, just to be sure.” Wade shifted the weaponized accessory in his hand, moving so that the handle was visible. “For limiting how the purses are used, I recommend adding a fingerprint authentication feature that is set up upon purchase. It will create a record of which purse belongs to which person, so identifying the ones wielded illegally will be a snap for law enforcement, and ensures a stolen purse can’t be used. Maybe toss in a GPS as well, along with a beacon that notifies local emergency services that help is needed whenever a spray is activated. We’ll also need some wireless charging capabilities to power the new additions. Now you’ve got a self-defense device that is a



pain in the ass to use illegally, but offers even more features to the people who are actually in trouble.”

“Sounds expensive,” Tori noted.

“It will be, but mass production, along with a few tricks I’ve picked up, should help reduce costs. Besides, you designed an item often classified as a luxury. With stylish enough designs and the features we’re adding, the price tag will justify itself.”

He wasn’t necessarily wrong, but it still nagged at Tori’s conscience. “Let’s keep at least a few of the models priced as low as they can go. This isn’t about only protecting rich people. No offense.”

To her surprise, Tori found Wade was no longer examining the purse, and had instead pointed that scrutinizing stare in her direction. “The desire to create change, to invent something which leaves a lasting mark upon the world... there is nothing wrong with that ambition. In fact, I daresay it’s the part of you I find most interesting. But ambition alone does not build an empire. You’ll have to make hard choices, and look to the bottom line more than you’ll want to. This concession is a small one, and I can easily make it. Understand that in the future, such may well not be the case.”

“Got it. If I want my stuff to be universally available, I have to build with that in mind.”

“Along with hoping the projects don’t change form in development, but that’s more of a long-term concern.” Gently, Wade handed the purse back over to Tori. “For today, I think it’s safe to say we’re on an excellent track. If you’d be open to it, I can take a crack at adding the additional features, since I’ve got more experience building computer components for mass production. However, if you’d prefer to do it all by hand, I understand, and we can schedule another progress meeting down the line.”

It was no accident that he’d given the purse back before asking; they both knew Tori’s general capacity for trust, especially where her work was concerned. Taking it and adding the suggestions would be doable, but slower than anything Wade could manage, especially with her suit repairs still ongoing. Beyond that, for this partnership to work, at a certain point, Tori would have to let it out of her hands. Since she wasn’t planning to make each of these things personally, loosening her grip was simply unavoidable. Better for Wade to show his true colors now, early on, if there was going to be a betrayal. Tori couldn’t control that part, though. All she could do was present him with an opportunity.

“I say give it a shot.” Tori dropped the purse back on the table, where it had started. “I’ll obviously want to look things over, but you can get us a build closer to the mass-market version anyway, so it makes more sense to start from there.”

“Your trust is noted, and appreciated,” Wade informed her. “I should be able to have something ready by next week. It would be sooner, if not for the upcoming hecticness.”

That was certainly one way to categorize a planned alien invasion. Tori might have to steal that the next time she was alluding to an upcoming villain event—at the rate things had been going, the damn things were sure frequent enough.

“Until then, I suggest you focus on personal preparations, especially where self-defense is involved.”

“You don’t have to tell me twice,” Tori concurred. “After one stop at Ridge City Grinders, I’m heading back to the base to keep working.”

She pointedly didn’t mention why she was stopping for coffee, not that anyone she knew in the guild would require such an explanation. For Tori, it was a perfectly natural detour—would have been stranger if she skipped her favorite java spot. It was much easier to let that assumption slide than to explain she was grabbing a drink with her friend who was also one of the AHC’s rising stars. It wasn’t a secret, per se, just something she chose not to talk about.

After what she’d learned about Ivan and Helen, Tori was starting to suspect there were a great many things so hidden by the guild members. It was only fair she rack up a few of her own.

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## Chapter 98

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“Mommy? Are you okay?”

With a start, Helen jerked upward, feigning wakefulness as best she could. The effort was severely compromised by the document stuck to her face, pasted there by ill-timed slumbering drool during the unexpected nap. Thankful there were no photographers around to capture this candid moment, Helen yanked the page off, setting it back onto her kitchen table with the others, right where it had been before the boredom and sleepiness overtook her.

“Mommy is doing fine, just taking a short rest when she can. How about you? How’s packing coming along?”

Penelope’s eyes turned downward, a sure sign that no productive report was impending. “I packed three shirts, twelve socks, and my comfy snow pants.”

Sighing, Helen reached down and scooped up her daughter. At six, she was no longer the tiny bundle that could easily fit in a single grip, yet there was no twinge from her back or cry from her arms as she lifted the small human with a squeal of delight. For all that her power had taken through the years, there were other gifts it left behind. Never truly losing the ability to sweep up those she loved in her grasp was one that Helen treasured.

“I know you don’t want to go with Miss Theresa this weekend, but she’s going to take you somewhere secure. An emergency bunker, with lots of supplies, where you’ll be safe no matter what happens.”

The small head dug into her collarbone, pressing hard. “But you won’t be there.”

“No, honey. Mommy can’t be down there. Mommy has to do her part to keep everyone safe.” She kissed the top of Penelope’s head, all too aware that there was no happy end to the conversation in sight. Her daughter was afraid. She knew something bad was coming. For all that Helen wanted to be there with her, telling her that it would be okay, she had to be Lodestar, ensuring that such an outcome was actually possible.

“Can Uncle Ivan come?”

Ridiculous as the notion of Ivan Gerhardt walking into an AHC-owned bunker was, for a moment, Helen found the image deeply comforting. Truth be told, if there had to be one person that wasn’t Lodestar watching over Penelope, Ivan would be at the top of the list. Hopefully, he’d be spending the invasion protecting Rick and Beth. This problem was squarely within the AHC’s jurisdiction, so she didn’t expect much guild activity. Or rather, she hoped there wouldn’t be much—because if the guild had a chance to play, it meant that things would have gotten very messy indeed.

“No, honey, Uncle Ivan has another safe place to be. But there will be other kids to play with, new people to meet, and the whole thing shouldn’t take more than a day or two. Can you be my brave girl for that long?”

Uncertain squirming made for a potent tell, yet Penelope still screwed her face up into a curiously familiar expression. “I can do it. You go save the world.”

In her decades as a superhero, even before fully coming into her powers, there were only a handful of blows that hit as hard as that look. Helen knew that expression, because she’d seen it on her own face so many times throughout the years. It was the face of someone hiding their own pain to put on a brave front for the sake of those watching. Thanks to her job, Helen had worn that mask untold times, but she’d never hated it so fundamentally until she saw her daughter do the same.

“How about I help you pack? We’ll pick out some fun outfits you can show everyone, and think of lots of games for you to play with the other kids.” It wouldn’t make up for being gone when her daughter was scared, but it was something. Helen would deal with the paperwork later; super-speed made for sloppier work, however she didn’t especially care. With only a few days left until the world was at risk, Helen was going to spend the time she had where it mattered most.

That was one lesson life refused to stop teaching her.



Almost time.

The man pressed his thin fingers together, hoping the latest round of coverage could contain his excitement until the moment was at hand. The materials for coating himself enough to maintain an appearance of humanity weren't exactly easy to come by, even if he did make the vast majority of them himself. There were still components to consider, some getting rarer by the year. Over time, he'd attempted to adjust the formula, substituting in newer materials for those falling out of availability. Each such experiment ended in disaster. Were he capable of death, several would have likely ended him entirely.

"We just... wait?" Lozora hung in the corner of the room, an attack dog no longer sure of her usefulness. She was wise to be uncertain; her presence was tolerable only so long as it served a purpose. Fortune remained on her side for the moment, as there were still tasks for which she was suitable.

"We are not waiting. We are preparing for the perfect moment to strike," he clarified. "Once the attack begins, some of the assets I've reached out to under my cover identity will move into position, drawing our targets to the appropriate location. Our aim is set, the hammer cocked. It is merely a matter of letting everything properly align to take it all in a single shot."

Her next words were mumbled, perhaps not truly meant for him to hear. "Seems like there are easier ways to kill some capes."

"Countless simpler methods," he agreed instantly. "Yet this is not a job built toward efficiency. It is about the spectacle, the show, and the aftermath of what remains. If simply 'killing capes' were all I had in mind, this would have been finished on the first day. I seek something far more delicious, and difficult."

His thin hands stretched out before him, the pale skin clinging to the finger bones like cheap shrink-wrap. "What I want is to take decades of pain, a lifetime of suffering, an endless torment with no escape, and gift even a small portion of it to someone else. Killing the capes will be the finale, a grand flourish to drive things home. All the hell I put them through before that is the purpose. I want them to know, even briefly, the cost of their power. Only when they understand the truth will death be allowed."

Lozora said nothing to that. She'd been especially quiet since the Starscout incident. She didn't matter, anyway. Her role could be easily filled

by multiple lesser minions at this point. The plan was what counted. He'd worked so hard to move everything into position, just to create a perfect opening.

With only a few days left until the fun started, he could scarcely contain himself, as the slow leak of dark smoke rising from his left pinky attested. There was probably enough material left to last for another coating before the invasion, but after that, he'd be running low.

Then again, after the invasion, he might enjoy a little time living in his own visage. After so long spent unseen and unknown, it was well past time he showed the capes what they were really up against.



It took Tori a moment to spot Donald amidst the bustle of Ridge City Grinders. Only the good fortune of Chloe being on shift made things easier, as her roommate gave a pointed nod to a table in the corner, where some douchebag was wearing a hat and sunglasses indoors. On her second look, Tori realized the douchebag in question *was* Donald, which was all the prompting she needed to kick off the conversation.

"You going to a brightly lit baseball game in the next ten minutes, or just auditioning for 'World's Most Obvious Narc'?" Tori smiled down at him, softening the blow slightly.

"Oh, hey!" Donald leapt up, stowing his phone at the apparent realization of her arrival. Working with the AHC was already a busy gig; she had to imagine. With what the weekend was bringing, that was even more the case. It made the fact that he'd coordinated with her schedule for coffee catch-up session to happen all the more impressive, and worrying.

Tori still wasn't sure where she'd landed on the idea of capes and villains being friends. Helen and Ivan were proof that it could work, yet she was smart enough not to base too much of her life around Lodestar and Fornax. Those two tended to be exceptions a lot of the time; it was best to not take them as the standard. Nevertheless, they proved it was possible, for those who put in the work.

As their hug broke apart, she caught the sheepish look on Donald's face. "I... um... I've had to start keeping a lower profile in public lately. Cyber Geek is getting more popular."

“Isn’t that a good thing?” She clapped him on the back once, though he didn’t seem especially enthusiastic.

“It’s not a bad one, but it takes some getting used to. For today, I wanted to be incognito.”

“Then I’m glad I caught you before any browser windows were open. Hang on, let me go grab a drink.” As Tori turned, she found herself looking at the approaching form of Chloe, who set a large cup on the table in front of her.

She only paused long enough to add a napkin to the top of the cup. “I made you the afternoon usual, plus a little extra. Tell me how the meeting went later tonight.” Then Chloe was gone, back into the fray of cranky caffeine consumers.

With no more need for detours, Tori took her seat, sipping the coffee, unsurprised to find it scorching hot. Chloe had probably made the thing, and then tossed it in an oven to stay warm—not like she had to worry about burning Tori’s tongue.

“Big day with the Vendallia higher-ups?”

It took Tori a moment to figure out what he meant. She was currently so mentally checked out of her day job that the words almost seemed nonsensical. After a stuttering start, her brain finally kicked into gear, putting together his meaning. Luckily, large sips of coffee were excellent for hiding mental recalibration.

“In a way, sort of, though only in the most technical sense.” Tori hesitated. This wasn’t a development she was ready to share with the world yet, not even amongst friends. “I’m working on something new, but I don’t really want to talk about it until I see if it’s going somewhere.”

“I’ve seen the quality of work you can do at a job you tolerate. If it’s something you actually care about, I’m sure you’ll knock it out of the park.” Donald was squirming now, and Tori realized his own drink, an iced coffee turned light from all the added cream, had barely been drunk a quarter of the way, despite his head start. He was... nervous.

Instantly, the scene changed for Tori. Every single body in the building was a potential cape in disguise. Did Chloe know? No, she’d have found to way to slip in some sort of message, or used one of her idioms to escape. What was the plan? Ambush her while the suit wasn’t around, subdue her if she was lucky, then drag her to court for... for what, exactly?

Forcing a few deep breaths down under the guise of a very long swig, Tori took control of herself. Awareness and fear were useful tools; giving over to full-blown paranoia was another matter entirely. Nerves didn't mean Donald was about to turn on her. He had plenty going on this week to be worried about. And even if she was busted, the only crime Hephaestus was wanted for was a connection to a museum heist, something that the guild lawyers could hopefully handle. More than anything, though, if the AHC wanted to haul her in, Lodestar could have done it whenever she chose.

"Here's hoping you're right." Tori gave a mock toast, which Donald mirrored, albeit on a delay. "Anyway, what wins me time with one of Ridge City's rising capes? Don't get me wrong, it's nice to catch up, but you seemed pretty set on making something happen this week when we were texting."

Of course, Tori knew the reason: Donald was facing down an invasion and was afraid. He was doing what people facing real battle often saw as the best use of their time: spending it with friends and family. Even if she had to feign ignorance, Tori was touched as she realized how important that made their friendship to him—a kind feeling that was followed swiftly by remembering how easily she'd thought him willing to betray her moments ago.

"There's... I've got a mission coming up," Donald said, quite nearly slipping up right out of the gate. "You probably don't need to worry or anything. No one expects me to be in particular danger."

"But life doesn't come with guarantees, especially for capes." That was a truth Tori had understood long before guilds and abilities. She was a smart cookie. Life only had to savagely rip away everyone she loved *once* for the message to sink in.

He nodded, though he didn't seem much more at ease, despite her jumping them to the punch. "That's definitely a big part of it. I've started to really understand how powerful some metas out there are, and how wildly out of my depth I could be with even just one wrong move. I don't want to make the mistake of assuming things will go well, and then end up being wrong."

Softly, Tori reached over and patted him on the forearm. "Dude, you're *allowed* to be scared. These powers aren't a change you asked for. They just happened. The fact that you chose to do something constructive with them at all is amazing. Most people would have kept it to themselves or used it



for personal gain. Expecting yourself to take on criminals and monsters without ever being afraid, well, that's just dumb."

"It isn't that kind of fear. I mean, yes, I might get hurt, but that's true any time I go out on patrol. I've had to make peace with that for a while now. My bigger concern is leaving things unsaid."

Without warning, Donald's free hand came down lightly on top of the one Tori had been using to pat his forearm. He looked at her, eyes not quite fully shielded by the reflective glasses, thanks to the angle of the lighting. That was why she could see bits of the terror, and sincerity, in his gaze. Too late, those clues finally gave her an inkling of what this meeting was really about.

"Tori, I asked you here because the truth is... I have feelings for you."

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## Chapter 99

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The first five passes came up empty. Luckily, no one appeared to notice the streak that blasted by Ridge City Grinders multiple times. On try number six, Kyle arrived outside the window just in time to see Tori laying her hand on Donald's arm. His pulse spiked, in a way that had nothing to do with the speeds he was operating at. Unlike many of his peers, Kyle was somewhat in touch with his own feelings, meaning he understood quite well what was happening.

At some point, he'd become taken with Tori. It wasn't all that shocking—his past romantic affections had often landed on headstrong women with forceful personalities. Mix in that she was one of the few people outside of the island who'd treated them all like their positions didn't matter, making her the only outsider he'd ever been able to open up to, and it was practically inevitable.

Recognizing that those feelings existed wasn't the same as giving into them, however. They were in Ridge City to continue a legacy, while building something new of their own. One day, maybe, he could free up enough of himself to put into a relationship, but for now, Kyle knew he would always pick the job and team first, which wasn't fair to any prospective partner. Especially one who clearly had other prospects. So while he did feel his pulse rise, it wasn't accompanied by any sort of impulse to dash over and interrupt.

While a piece of Kyle was tempted to slip inside and listen in, he'd already made enough mistakes where Tori was concerned, and for this one, he wouldn't even have the power of self-delusion. Catching a moment in

happenstance was one thing; if she caught him purposefully snooping, there rightfully might be no forgiveness.

With one last look through the window, Kyle disappeared in a sudden blur.



Finding the right response was no easy feat. For a dangerous heartbeat, she almost tried to laugh it off, but the look on Donald's face was much too vulnerable. Her next impulse, a new standard in terrible, was to blurt out that she was really Hephaestus. Both were resisted as Tori opted—rather than blow up the conversation and attached friendship—to try to muddle her way through. Not being sure about her future friendship with Donald didn't mean she wanted to hurt him, regardless of how things went.

"Look... I'm about to say something, and it's going to sound like a line, so you have to hear me all the way out, okay?"

"Of course," Donald replied.

Tori took a sip of her coffee to steel her nerves. "You're a great guy, but —"

The groan that slipped out of Donald was plainly unintentional, as his eyes went wide in embarrassed surprise moments later. "Sorry, sorry, just wasn't expecting an *actual* verbatim dumping line."

"Warned you." Tori tossed a small smile on, lightening the mood as much as she dared, given the subject matter. "And like I was saying, you *are* a great guy. The issue is me. I'm... there are a lot of parts of my life that you don't know about. Really, truly messed-up parts."

"I get that things were rough for a long time. Losing your parents, the addiction—I can't imagine what you went through. That said, none of it would change who you are today."

"You're wrong. It's done nothing *but* shape who I am today." Tori felt the rage in her gut rising without provocation, just because she'd dared look into her own history. It was always there, in the spot where happy memories of her family and childhood were supposed to live. The endless blaze of fury over a life stolen from her, not even by something as ineffable as fate, but by simple greed and apathy. One more broken piece in the pile that was Tori Rivas.

“I have a lot of trust issues. I mean, a shitload. Right now, the only way I can seem to make genuine friends is to share some sort of near-traumatic battle with them, which isn’t really a healthy or sustainable tactic. As for romantic relationships, they aren’t even on my radar. I don’t know what sort of emotional bandwidth you need to open up like that, but I don’t have it. Not now. Maybe not ever.”

It was Donald’s turn to use his beverage as a way to buy time, an extra-long slurp punctuating the pause after Tori’s words. At last, he lowered it, reply finally formed. “That might be the first time someone has used ‘it’s not you, it’s me’ and been entirely sincere.”

“Molds were made to be broken.”

His gaze softened, despite the bad news. “Clearly.” After a moment, he composed himself, looking a tad bashful at the earnest admiration. “If that’s how you really feel, then I can respect it. While it’s not the answer I wanted, I didn’t honestly expect you to feel the same way. I’m sure I’ve got a type out there, it’s just very specific.” Donald leaned back slightly, eyes moving toward the shop at large, as if scanning for an exit from this now embarrassing situation.

To no one’s shock more than her own, Tori’s hand shot out, grabbing him by the wrist. “Hey. Stop. I meant what I said. You *are* a solid guy, Donald. Kind, honest, and loyal to a fault. Even brave, nowadays. You’re a damn cape, for god’s sake. There is no shortage of women out there who would love to be on Cyber Geek’s arm. Just because I’m not one of them doesn’t mean I’ll let you shit-talk my friend.”

“It wasn’t much of a shit-talking,” Donald protested.

“Sentiment more than words; I can still read between the lines. The point is, you *are* my friend.” Tori realized the words were true only as they were tumbling unbidden from her mouth. “Assuming you’re okay with that, after my answer.”

The response wasn’t instantaneous. As Tori pulled her hand back, Donald appeared to give the matter a few seconds of serious thought before finally nodding his head. “I’d love to still be friends. But, fair warning, I also don’t think I can turn off my feelings just like that. I won’t bring it up again and will try my best not to let anything show; it just might take time. I don’t want you to think I’m hanging around in the wings, using our friendship as a way to wait and see if you change your mind.”

“If I’d had a few more friends like you throughout my life, I might not be such a fucked-up mess.” Tori relaxed a little, now that the conversation was on a more predictable track. “It’s okay for you to feel however you want, so long as you respect my own thoughts on the subject.”

Despite the positive swing, Donald’s face creased, the first time in the whole talk he’d looked genuinely bothered. “Good. Then as your friend, I don’t like when you do that.”

“Do what?”

“Do what? The exact thing you just got on me about: shit-talking my friend. You’re not a ‘fucked-up mess,’ Tori. You’re holding down a job, a social life, an apartment of your own. I know people who haven’t been through a tenth of what you have, and they still can’t get it together enough to do their own laundry. Give yourself an ounce of credit from time to time.”

Her impulse was to deny and defer, pretend all of that was mere happenstance. And to an extent, it was, in the sense that only chance had gotten her on the guild’s radar, leading to her apprenticeship with Ivan. Yet that was merely the opportunity; everything from there on had been done by Tori’s own hand. She’d endured the guild’s trials, she’d survived the Ridge City Riots, she’d built the identity of Hephaestus. Maybe he was right. Perhaps she was a little too hard on herself.

“Well then, how about we both promise to be better about going easy on ourselves, and hold one another accountable to it?” Tori lifted her coffee once more, noting that Donald did the same without even looking. “To friends?”

His reply was as instant as it was earnest. “I’ll always drink to that.”



“And what makes this place so safe, exactly?” Janet was rubbing the spot above her nose between her eyes, giving Ivan deep flashbacks to the later years of their marriage. That gesture had been in frequent use as the arguments grew more constant. He briefly wondered if she used it around anyone else—it would seem not, if today was any indication. Juan was at work and the kids were in school; this was a meeting solely for those in the

know about the greater events of their world. Specifically, the weekend's coming danger.

"Guild owned, heavily reinforced, and with an emergency escape option in the event things go catastrophically wrong." It was all the more galling that they had to hash this out when he *knew* she was going to go along with it in the end. The other options were to take their chances out in the open, or turn to the AHC for help. Intelligence and pride cut off both those paths for Janet.

"Yes, but what good will that do if Earth loses?" Janet persisted. "Death by starvation as we remained trapped in your hidey hole isn't much better than getting wiped out in the initial shot."

It was hard to argue that she wasn't presenting a relevant concern, albeit one Ivan had trouble imagining. Thankfully, the possibility was one he'd also taken into account. "If Earth's defenses fall, then you'll use the escape option. We have a versal-displacement engine to punch a hole between this part of the multiverse and somewhere safe."

Janet's concern was momentarily tempered by her curiosity—the same trait that had gotten them mixed up together in the first place. "I thought it was near impossible to break through the multiverse barriers anymore."

"Then you also know Wade considers the words 'near impossible' to be the start of a challenge," Ivan explained. "It takes a tremendous amount of power, and the portals only last for a short while, so it's still a huge ordeal. But the technology functions well enough that we built an emergency escape system and established an outpost where we can flee to."

He didn't add that this system wasn't designed with aliens in mind. For all they knew, the Wrexwren were just as far ahead on that front as humanity. No, this safety mechanism was built with a single force in consideration. For all the power Lodestar had, she was completely unable to leave her native universe. All the nooks, subspaces, dimensions, and planes of their own world were fair game, but no Lodestar they'd heard of had ever been able to step beyond the initial universe they inhabited. Which made fleeing to another part of the multiverse the only true way to slip from that powerful, glowing grasp.

"Meaning if things go badly, our best option is to leave the entire world behind?" The words could have sounded patronizing or sarcastic; instead, there was a cold calculation to them. She grasped the stakes at play, and that failure from Earth's defenders meant the entire world they knew could

come tumbling down. Janet wanted to be sure she understood the consequences to every action as she made them. It was an attitude Ivan had worked hard to learn from during their time together.

“Yes. If I fall, it means these creatures are incredibly dangerous, and the world is in for a harsh battle. Should Lodestar fall... just get out. If they hold power greater than hers, this planet cannot stand against it.”

Janet rolled her eyes with outstanding form; however, not even she bothered to argue on this point. “I do feel better knowing there’s a contingency, although it would have been nice to look over the other world’s facilities in advance. Our best option is not to need it, to stay put in our own universe. Tell me you’re going to win this, Ivan.”

“My part is relatively simple. The harder tasks fall upon Wade, Xelas, and Lodestar.”

“That’s not what I said.” Janet rose from her kitchen table, striding over to the corner of the room and plucking up a set of framed photos. She walked back, thumb resting on the image in the rightmost corner. “Do you remember that day?”

He took the photos from her hands. Janet appeared to be standing on a dusty road, in front of a natural rock formation, posing with the infant version of Rick. All of that was true and accurate; what was unseen, just outside of frame, were the front gates of Rookstone, where Ivan had been imprisoned at the time. The picture was from the day he’d first met his son, taken less than an hour prior to the event.

“I could never forget.” He remembered every piece of it. The uncertainty in Janet’s eyes, the sharp sting of the cleaning spray lingering in the prison air, the tiny fingers that grabbed at his hands before balling up into a fist, clenching on the orange fabric of Ivan’s uniform until Rick was taken away. Even then, the small hand hung on, tugging the collar in a way that had never truly gone from Ivan’s mind.

“Do you remember what you told me before I left?”

“I won’t let anything happen to him.”

The sharp “tsk” hissed out of Janet’s closed teeth instantly. “Those weren’t your words.”

Ivan’s eyes traveled from the starting photo to the rest of the frame. He was missing in most of these, but there was no shortage of pictures documenting his children’s lives. Babies, to toddlers, now one nearing her teens and the other verging toward adulthood.

“I will kill every meta, every monster, every world, if it means keeping our child, our children, safe. No price is too high, no blood is too sacred. I *will* protect them.”

“That’s what I wanted to hear.” Janet gently plucked the photograph from his hands, looking up at him with a small touch of her former admiration. “Now, you’re ready to fight.”



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## Chapter 100

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Contact came on Friday. Specifically, Friday morning, just between when Professor Quantum wrapped his current project of upgrading his flight belt and when he returned to the lab with an ultra-energy bar. He'd already half unwrapped the glowing treat when he stepped into his facilities to find every piece of communications equipment lighting up. Those tricky little invaders were trying to send it worldwide, stirring up panic among the masses before they'd even set a single ship in Earth's space.

Such a mass broadcast was impossible without tripping the AHC's blocking equipment, and while there were, admittedly, a few other metas capable of bypassing the media defense, the days of screens suddenly filling with criminals were largely long-past. There were obvious exceptions, like that traitor Apollo teaching Balaam the ways around it for their little rebellion, but those were insider tricks. An alien force wouldn't have knowledge of such tactics, so for the moment, this message was only for the AHC, and anyone else who'd rigged up a functioning interstellar communications array.

Looking over the content of the message as his automated translator was spitting it out, there was nothing surprising thus far. This was a twenty-four hour notice: the battle would begin in a day's time. Earth was allowed to send up a champion if they so chose, losing would forfeit their planet to be plundered—all the standard bits they were already expecting. The only real unknown to be revealed was the timetable. A single day, enough to technically give the planet a chance to ready their defenses, yet still with most of the benefits of a surprise attack.

There was sharp crack and a minor flash of light as Professor Quantum took a large bite from his bar, the crumbs dissolving as soon as they hit the ground. Now that they knew the invasion was planning to move soon—within a day, if they were telling the truth—it was time to bring the public in on what was happening. In the old days, they'd have just let the sky fill up with aliens and tell people to have faith. Now, everyone expected these sorts of things to be added right to their calendar. Lodestar coddled this world too much. Professor Quantum was of the mindset that tribulation built character. Not a fight worth having on this front, though, especially not when the issue would have the public on her side.

Instead, he activated the preprogrammed sequence, sending out the recorded video across the world, the computer redubbing over their voices in various languages to ensure it was understood by all who saw. While he might not have loved the necessity of communication, Professor Quantum would never permit his work to fall below acceptable quality.

On his screen, and across millions stretching out through every corner of the globe, a new image suddenly appeared. On it was himself, Quorum, and at the front, speaking, was Lodestar. Time to bring the world up to speed on what the weekend held in store.



Across the world, people drew near to their screens and speakers, all too aware of what an announcement like this foretold. Families huddled closer, souls were searched, and each person faced the momentary possibility that everything they'd ever known or loved could be destroyed in a single day's time. Then, for the most part, they continued on with their respective days. An invasion on the horizon was all well and good, but it didn't change the work ahead of them, and once the AHC kicked the attackers back to the far reaches of space, things would be back to normal by Monday.

Some took the news more seriously than others. In one particularly well-armed Ridge City household, for example, the entire family was engaged in cleaning and checking their entire stock of weapons. Ambrose watched the screen as he reassembled a rifle, not needing his eyes for a task so well burned into his muscles. Beverly had called it, and days before the AHC. Something big was coming all right, and she'd wanted to make sure

her family was ready for it. Part of him wondered if he should be probing deeper into *how* exactly she'd had access to that sort of information, but they were already in the process of getting reestablished after the transformation incident. Better to let her reveal the truth in time. For now, he had plenty to keep busy with.

Beth and Rick saw the announcement on their phones, inside a car already headed out of town. Beth was mostly interested and excited, while Rick couldn't help thinking about this trip they'd mysteriously decided to take beforehand. It all tied back to his dad's secret somehow, though for the moment, he was content to let that sleeping dog lie. Learning just a taste of the truth had terrified him to the core of his soul. Right now, he was happy to have Ivan just be his dad. Yet even as he held that thought, Rick's eyes wandered out the window to the blue sky overhead. When the dust settled, did he really expect a man who'd killed—or rather, *slaughtered* an entire army, to just sit back and watch?

Sitting at his stool, surrounded by terrified locals, Grantham watched the old tube set flickering as it blasted out the message in a language he'd only picked up the basics of. He'd been around long enough to get the essentials: there was a fight coming, and the AHC was trying to keep it off-world. Keeping his beer soundly on the table, Grantham flexed his left hand into a fist. Veins bulged an icy blue hue, a shade that spread across the arm, swelling it with muscle at even the merest thought of combat. Smiling, he used his right hand to take a sip of beer, not even caring that it had dropped by several degrees. He wasn't ready to take on the AHC yet, but Jokull might have fun tearing through some easier targets.

Chloe watched the announcement along with everyone else at Ridge City Grinders. It was strange, seeing this message while practically sitting in the AHC's shadow. People were obviously scared, yet not sure how afraid they should really be. Daunting as the concept was, it was hardly the first time Earth had been attacked at large, and so far, the capes had succeeded in repelling back every major threat. Then again, they only had to lose once for the planet to be wiped out, a fact that everyone was trying hard not to think about. Her customers absorbed the message like a small blow, then each began the process of walking it off. The rest of the world would deal in its own way; this was just part of what it took to build a life in Ridge City.

Sitting atop the Statue of Lizardy, which rested directly across from the Statue of Liberty, Captain Bullshit's hand stayed, despite being moments away from summoning the sarsaparilla storm clouds. The clunky old mobile television was easily four times bigger than a modern phone, and with far worse picture, but it still held a signal well enough to get the message. While he was disappointed to scrap the performance, such a display was no longer needed today. The world had already been reminded to expect the unexpected; to strike again at their cocoons of repetition would be mental assault, rather than the art of cerebral elevation. This could wait for another day, when the masses' minds were properly aligned for radical shocks.

On an island nation off the coast of Australia's Shattered Shores, the message was blazing on a huge screen, higher in definition than most people even realized was possible. The figure seated upon a mechanical throne took in every detail, face inscrutable through her meta-suit's seamless helmet. It flowed into the rest of the armor, which coated every inch of the wearer's body. Her fingers tapped heavily against the armrest, calculating the odds of AHC failure. Chances were strong they would repel the threat, though whether or not they would succeed without the Earth taking damage was more in question. Whatever the outcome, Tyranny was confident in her nation's defenses. Her land would either endure, or tear off the enemy's flesh on their way out. Leaning over, she whispered to a figure at her side, the only person in the chamber with her. Confident or not, there were preparations to be made.

Nexus had no grand view to watch from for this part. He was only around happenstantially, in case this was one of the versions where Captain Bullshit went ahead with the storm. Standing on the street, he could see the image playing on several screens in various stores and windows, none of which he paid attention to. The message wasn't inherently fascinating, especially after hearing countless prior versions of it. What came next, now *that* he would have several good seats for. This was little more than the curtain call. With no sarsaparilla storm on the horizon, Nexus soon vanished, popping out of the world like he'd been digitally removed. Only for a bit, though.

Come tomorrow, this would be an event he dared not miss.



Tori and Ivan didn't see the announcement. They weren't intentionally avoiding it; however, there were no television screens in the testing chamber, and neither had elected to bring a phone along with them for this.

Zippering through the air, Tori adjusted her flight path, nimbly getting around one of the cardboard protrusions popping down from the ceiling. As she did, a fresh target popped into view, earning a short blast from the gauntlet on her left arm.

In all but title and a few small suit pieces, she was once more Hephaestus—or at least, she would be once this test was complete. It wasn't really for Ivan; he'd simply wanted to see where she was at. The real assessor was Tori herself, keenly observing every detail of her suit's performance post-repair. So far, it was holding up splendidly, the few limitations she hit being ones of design and fatigue. No amount of repairing would change the fact that she'd put the armor through more than its initial materials were meant to endure. Between learning in the field and access to superior components, Tori was slowly coming around to the fact that soon, she'd need to build an entirely new meta-suit. Projects like this were never done. Each design reached the full extent of its potential, and from that knowledge, a next step forward could be taken.

Reorienting with a quick spin, Tori fired at two more targets with the left gauntlet. Her right was cycling into its large beam weapon. For all the work she'd done on efficiency, there was still a sizable charging time before her big shots could be used. Not ideal in the field, so she needed to make a habit of keeping one blast ready to go whenever possible. The rapid turns earned her groans from the suit's dark metal. Between fighting with metas and the strain of flying at high speeds, she was going to have to go far more durable for the next incarnation, assuming she could find something both strong and light enough—there was no way she was parting with flight.

Settling into a rough hover, Tori scanned around, isolating two more targets as they flopped out into view. A pair of shots, and both were smoldering pieces of cardboard seconds later. Carefully, keeping a close eye on her stabilizers, Tori brought her suit back down to the ground, coming to a halt roughly ten feet from Ivan. She disengaged the helmet's latches, popping it off as her body reformed to flesh and bone. "Now that's a way to start a morning! What did you think?"

"Very impressive." Ivan didn't actually *sound* terribly impressed, though Tori knew that if she was waiting for that to happen, her next

invention had better be the world's comfiest chair. "Your mobility is constantly increasing as you improve the flight systems, and the gravitational distorters have even made you light on your feet. Aim seems accurate, force is adequate, though I notice you didn't test the major weapons."

Even without her helmet showing the indicator, Tori could tell her gauntlet was still charged; there was a crackling, static-like energy running along the length of her arm. Crap, that meant she needed to reinforce the shielding before there was a major rupture. That issue would have shown in the charging, though, so it was probably still safe-ish to use. "Wasn't quite sure what these walls were rated for. Figured Wade had enough on his plate without me cutting a hole in the base."

"A bit overconfident, though you do make a good point." Ivan took several steps back, then raised his hands out in front, like he was pushing an invisible wall. "Whenever you're ready."

"For mime-work? Hate to be the bearer of bad news, but you're going to be holding that position for a hell of a long time."

Ivan sighed with the exhausted resolve that only a parent raising a teen was capable of. "For the fully charged beam. We're testing all of your suit. That certainly includes your ace in the hole. The walls' durability can be called into question. Mine is a known quantity, especially when braced. So, as I said, whenever you're ready."

There was no reason why Tori's arm hesitated before shifting into position. Ivan was, so far as she knew, borderline indestructible. Her absolute best efforts might be able to put a scratch or a burn on him, but causing actual damage was currently a pipe dream. All the same, it was momentarily difficult to point her greatest weapon at the man who'd fast become one of the few positive constants in her life, even knowing how silly her fear was.

In that moment, just before she fired, Tori finally understood how Ivan could feel protective over Lodestar, despite how fantastically nonsensical and pointless it was. Whatever the rational brain might know, it didn't quiet the fearful voice that lived much deeper down, the whispering tone terrified to lose someone its owner cared about.

The beam of energy scorched the air, blazing through the short distance between them in a flash. That was the furthest it went, however. Ivan's hands, still stretched before him, didn't just stop the beam, they contained

it. It was like he'd hefted some invisible shield, which wasn't the worst way to describe magical wards, soaking up all the power she'd sent hurtling in his direction.

Finally, when the beam cut out, Ivan waited a few seconds, then lowered his arms. His hands were rubbed against one another, then shaken out, like they'd been slept on and had to be roused from numbness. "I could feel that."

"What does that mean?" Her gauntlet was smoking—she definitely needed to tweak the shielding before the invasion kicked off. Still, Tori felt the first whispers of pride rising in her chest, wondering if she'd managed something especially impressive.

"Many things. That you've increased the power from the last time I took one of these shots by quite a bit. That you'll be capable of damaging all but the most durable of metas." A hand landed on the armor of her shoulder, patting her twice. "And it certainly means that, should you choose to enter the fray tomorrow, I won't have to worry about Hephaestus making it through safely. That villain will have more than enough power to survive."

Good as the praise made Tori feel, she wasn't quite sure that survival would be her only goal once the invasion started. The majority of her life had been focused on having no attachments, caring for nothing, so that she couldn't be hurt by losing it again. For better or worse, the last year had chipped away at that tactic, one friendship at a time. Helen was right. She could keep pretending to not give a shit, but that wouldn't actually lessen the pain she'd feel to have someone taken away. If she wanted to protect the people she cared for, it was time to have a hard, honest reflection about who those folks really were.

Once she knew, Hephaestus could decide in the moment how to react to whatever the invaders threw at them. Tori might not have much insight into their game plan, but she had a pretty good idea of her own: defend what was hers, and show any dumb sonsabitches who tested Hephaestus why it was *never* a good idea to try to steal from a villain.

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## Chapter 101

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“Those of you assembled before me, your primary task in the coming event is to maintain peace and stability among Earth’s citizens. When something like this occurs, there will always be those who assume the Alliance of Heroic Champions is too busy to deal with lower-tier crimes. On top of that, some people may give in to genuine panic, taking actions that endanger themselves and those around them. You are going to be out there, en masse, making sure there’s help for anyone who needs it.”

Lodestar floated before the massive assembly, more capes than Cyber Geek had even realized were working at their level. Then again, with the rotating shifts and ways they were spread out, there were plenty of other members he passed like a ship in the night. Plus, the AHC was always adding new members, albeit not in the same flood that had been around when Donald first joined. To his left was Medley, on his right were Hat Trick and Cold Shoulder. They’d arrived that evening as a unit, ready to receive orders for the coming madness.

“In the event that our visitors decide to take the fight to Earth, your focus should be on guiding and protecting civilians. We have more experienced superheroes standing by to deal with an actual invasion force—that’s not where you’ll do the most good. Those of you who’ve gone through evaluation and done well may be tasked with slightly more difficult jobs as needs demand; however, it is highly unlikely we will ask you to get into the fray.”

Her form rotated through the air, working to make eye contact, however fleeting, with each person in the crowd. Neither Professor Quantum nor



Quorum were present, not that Cyber Geek had expected them to be around. Given what the planet was facing, it already felt like a waste to have Lodestar here breaking things down. But then, the real trouble was still a sunrise away.

“Should they invade, for most of you, this will be your first experience in anything similar to true war. In the heat of combat, pitted against an enemy with ruthless intentions, you may be forced to make difficult ethical decisions. I can’t tell you how much force is the right amount, or if the final line has to be crossed. The circumstances you’ll be facing will have to inform that decision. Just remember that there are no undo’s in this world. A life that’s taken can never be reclaimed.”

It was a notion that had been sitting heavy in Cyber Geek’s gut ever since he learned about the planet’s current threat. He’d had no issue blasting through a monster that Nexus conjured from another world, but since then, he’d been largely dealing with humans who required a far more gentle touch. Killing an alien was a notion that left him feeling uncomfortable, yet was still something he could imagine. Were it a human, Cyber Geek was fairly sure he wouldn’t be able to go through with it. He really hoped he wouldn’t have to find out if it was in him to kill a sentient being.

“We’re going to be working in rotations, since the chaos this causes will reach well outside the timetable we were given. First teams go out tonight, then back before dawn for some rest and recovery while the secondary teams work. It’ll go like that until we’re in the clear. I can’t promise we won’t hit an all-hands-on-deck situation at some point, so make sure to use your downtime well. There might only be so much of it.”

“First teams! Find a coordinator and get your starting position assignments. Second teams, hit the beds. You’re up in just a few hours.” This announcement came from one of the many people wearing polos bearing the AHC logo. Support staff were essential to keeping this place running, especially since so many other capes lacked Cyber Geek’s experience with office drudgery, along with his honed planning skills.

The crowd broke into movement instantly; they’d all had enough training to understand that speed was a factor in dangerous situations. By the time he looked back up to the ceiling, Lodestar was gone, zipped off to another of what had to be countless pre-invasion tasks. The polo-wearing staff were moving fast, too, dispatching teams and individuals to patrol

areas with blazing efficiency. When his team's turn came, there wasn't even a chance to speak.

"Ah, Cyber Geek's quartet—just one moment, please." The bespectacled man was slender and meek in a way that reminded Cyber Geek of himself less than a year prior. "Looks like you're on the home team. You'll be running patrols in Ridge City. No teleport needed. We'll route you as the night goes on. For starting off, let's have you begin near Ridge City Savings and Loan, swing wide around the Alfred Settler Memorial Plaza, then head up to Denny's Diamond Depot on fourth. By then, you'll have new directions waiting."

With their orders received, the team headed toward the main exit, a different direction than the vast majority of their peers, who were all being relocated to various locations. To his surprise, Cyber Geek noticed another group of four heading in the same direction. Waving, he caught the attention of Agent Quantum, who was walking with his own team. The big man returned the gesture, though there was still a bit too much crowd between them for anything verbal.

"At least we've got some heavy hitters hanging around," Medley noted. It was, by Cyber Geek's estimation, the first real compliment he'd ever paid the New Science Sentries.

"Let's just hope we don't need them," Hat Trick added.

"Because the threats are so weak, or we're so strong?" Cold Shoulder held up a bicep, perhaps intentionally showing off the results of her own training. Medley and Cyber Geek weren't the only ones hitting the gym lately.

"Ideally, because no one is in danger at all. I guess I'd settle for them being weak, though, since that would be easier for the average person to deal with." It was more or less the answer he'd expected from Hat Trick, though that didn't make her point any less salient.

It wasn't so long ago he'd been one of the normal humans, and he could still remember how terrifying it was in moments like these, when forces so far beyond anything he could fathom were gathered to determine his—along with the rest of the world's—fate. Hat Trick was spot on: the best outcome was one where nobody was in danger. Barring that, the next best thing was to make sure that if someone *was* in trouble, then there would be a superhero nearby to save the day.

“Everyone, grab a snack or some caffeine if you need it. We’ve got a lot of work to do.”



“Mobile, or fortified?” It was a strange question for Beverly to ask at a kitchen table next to bowls of Chloe’s half-burned spaghetti, even with the few empty beers scattered around. Laying in front of Beverly was a rough sketch of the neighborhood, with their building at the center. Based on the assessment they’d done over dinner, it was clear that holding this place during an invasion would be tricky. Like most apartment buildings, it wasn’t designed to resist real assault, only to keep unwanted trespassers out.

“With my hop-skip-and-jump phrase, we could change entire countries as needed. Even if the aliens come, there’s no way they can be everywhere,” Chloe pointed out. “Still a lot of planet to cover.”

Curious as she was about alien tech, Tori had been through one too many close calls lately to find any appeal in flying around, trying to hunt down invaders. Truth be told, in other circumstances she’d likely have holed up in the guild and let the whole ordeal pass, except they couldn’t very well bring Chloe along. She and Beverly had made sure to keep their friend off of both guild and AHC radar, since Chloe wanted to keep her normal life, extremely potent ability and all.

Considering the nature of the threat, mobile was absolutely the safer move. They could pop into some towns in the middle of a flyover state, the sort of place low on any invasion’s target list. Even if they picked wrong, Chloe could give them another shot within seconds. Mobile made them both efficient and safe.

And yet, Tori still felt a hitch in her stomach at the idea of fleeing. Ivan’s house had felt like her first home in a long while, and it had been destroyed—technically by her—during the last of these major catastrophes. This apartment, for all its faults, was *hers*. She’d chosen it with her friends, declared it to be her home, and even found herself missing it when she was away. Nexus had said it himself: a villain defends what was theirs. What was the point of having power if she was going to let some interstellar assholes push her around and wreck her home?

“I can’t speak for you two, but I don’t like the idea of running off and leaving this place for scavengers or aliens. If we try to stay here, we don’t lose our teleportation option. I propose we start by hunkering down, and then, if it becomes clear there’s no holding the line here, we bail out.”

“Running’s never really been my style, either,” Beverly agreed. Both eyes turned to Chloe, who was the heavier voice to weigh in on this discussion. She had no meta-suit, nor dragon-shifting. Her ability was strong, but strange, and certainly not the kind that could be counted on to keep her safe.

Scooping up two of the spaghetti bowls, Chloe brought them into the kitchen and dropped them on the counter, before returning, albeit not empty-handed. She’d grabbed the pink and black umbrella that always managed to somehow be in the same room or area as Chloe, despite none of them ever seeing it move, or even disappear. Sitting back down, she laid the umbrella down on the table.

“Last time I got involved in meta-human stuff, I accidentally exploded the top half of someone and ended up haunted by their indestructible umbrella. I definitely don’t want to do any fighting again, especially with outcomes like that, but I do have a little protection. I’ll stay with you two until it’s time to leave, and then we get clear. Fair?”

“Can’t reasonably ask for more than that,” Beverly agreed. “I think it’s a good plan. While we’re bracing for a fight, our exit strategy is impeccable. At the worst, we can strike hard, and then retreat.”

“Which brings us to our next question. We’ve got a single night to work with: what sort of defenses can we get in place before then?” Tori paused, looking over the rough diagram once more. “Ideally ones that don’t kill our neighbors or tip off the capes that there’s some sort of diabolical genius sharing the building with them.”

That earned her a raised eyebrow from Beverly. “Isn’t it a bit egotistical to call yourself a diabolical genius?”

“Humility is a virtue, so that shit is for the capes.”

“Touché.” A flash of thought darted through Beverly’s eyes. “Speaking of, should we expect any interference from them? Given that the New Science Sentries are on protective detail around you, they might be sticking close during an invasion.”

Crap. In all the madness of approaching aliens, Tori had forgotten their duty to her. Then again, if aliens ended up attacking the world, there was

little chance the New Science Sentries wouldn't get called to pitch in. No way they'd let a team like that ride the pine guarding one woman and her apartment. It was a thought that felt true, yet didn't quite reassure her fully.

"Nothing to be done. We have no idea where the AHC will put them, or even if aliens will show up at all, let alone come here specifically. But I think a good rule should be that we stay civilian until the first contact is reported, just in case they check in. An invasion would mean shit hitting the fan, so they'll have way more on their plate to deal with than me."

"There's always—" Chloe was cut off by a burst of sudden, fast knocking on the door, like someone was trying to pound out a rhythm.

Tori rose, putting the pieces together in short order. That sound was really just someone knocking normally, only sped up significantly. Unless the legendary Ricky Rocket had suddenly run back *into* reality, she had a pretty good hunch who this would be.

Sure enough, the door opened to reveal Tachyonic, looking almost jittery with the way he was fidgeting. Someone must have their speed cranked up substantially. The energy didn't extend merely to his body, even Tachyonic's voice came out at an accelerated pace.

"Hey Tori sorry to bother you in a bit of a hurry we're technically on patrol but I zipped over to let you know the AHC has us patrolling the city so please keep your head down and stay safe since we won't be next door plus I also snagged an emergency response clicker in case anything happens just hold the button down for five seconds and we'll get an alert okay gotta get back on patrol bye."

The words were a flurry, ending in a burst of wind as Tachyonic dashed back out to wherever it was he was actually supposed to be. Resting in Tori's hand was a small electronic button, like a stylized garage door opener: silver and with a large AHC logo emblazoned across the top. For a moment, she felt dirty, holding a thing like that, but the notion was quickly followed by intrigue. This was something that tapped into the AHC's communications network. If Professor Quantum had designed it, there would no doubt be safeguards on top of safeguards, but logically, he couldn't make every single piece of tech the AHC used. Some had to be crafted by other, lesser minds that weren't so skilled at protecting their creations.

Shutting the door, Tori turned back to her friends, who were watching with curious expressions. "Good news: I don't think we'll have to worry

about any capes. Now, if we can just convince the aliens to stay away, we might finally manage to have ourselves a goddamn peaceful weekend.”

Her friends laughed, and Tori chuckled as well, though there wasn't really much mirth in her at the moment. Tomorrow brought an element of unpredictable chaos, and there was no guarantee that when the dust settled, things wouldn't have changed. As someone who finally liked where her life was at, the idea scared Tori, the same fear that had helped act as a drive during her suit repairs.

When Tori felt afraid, her instinct was not to curl up and hide. Whatever was out there and coming to fuck with her, or the few people she cared about, would find a mad-eyed woman willing to fight tooth and nail to protect what was hers. Well, she'd certainly be willing to break *somebody's* teeth and nails, at any rate.

Whatever the Wrexwren were planning, Tori sure hoped they knew the fight they were in for. Otherwise, the savagery they were facing almost wouldn't feel fair.

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## Chapter 102

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When the Wrexwren ships first entered Earth's space, it was a very different event than the Grzzniltan visitation. Since the last extra-worldly visitors hadn't been bringing a fleet, there had been substantially less concern. This time, it seemed all but a given that there was a fight looming, and the citizens of Earth had endured too many such frays to be caught unaware. Families sheltered in place where possible, or banded together in large community centers. Weapons were passed out, and those with meta-human abilities were assigned roles best fitting to their talents. The world at large prepared to weather a storm from the far reaches of outer space.

Quorum and Professor Quantum were in the same room as Lodestar, where they'd been waiting and talking for the past hour, until this moment arrived. Another message lit up the equipment, a new transmission from the Wrexwren. On the large screen, dozens of imposing ships filled the sky: strange and alien, yet with the familiar hallmarks of machines made for war. Weapons, shielding, maneuverability—the exact shape might change, but the generalities remained the same. In the center was a larger vessel, almost like four balls of metal yarn: one at the center and three linked with tubing that seemed much too thin to exist outside the weightlessness of space.

“Signal source confirms, that's our mothership.” Professor Quantum ran a finger along the readout, checking carefully. “Whatever big object they're dragging, it's still managing to stay hidden from our censors. We can at least tell it is significantly behind them, though.”

“Which may or may not matter, depending what it is and how fast it can move,” Quorum added. “All we can safely presume is that it will not be

something that turns the tide in our favor.”

“Doesn’t really change anything, does it? I go handle the fight, you two take care of anything they try to pull while I’m gone. Any surprises, we roll with.” Lodestar couldn’t help staring at that void in their readings, even as she dismissed it. All of this felt too well-organized. For off-world invaders, everything seemed to be running smoothly. They had a plan, and while she didn’t know it yet, Lodestar also wasn’t convinced that things would go as easily as they hoped. Although, that could have easily just been the inner voice of experience.

Standing nearby, Professor Quantum finished reading over the communication. “Seems they’re ready to host guests. We’ve got thirty minutes to present a champion and claim the right to duel; otherwise, the invasion begins.”

“You’re getting ever faster at translations,” Quorum complimented.

“Yes, but also, they sent it in multiple Earth languages.” Professor Quantum seemed unbothered by the news—they’d already suspected the Wrexwren to have advanced information. This merely confirmed it.

“Half an hour isn’t a lot of time.” It wasn’t a concern, but Lodestar wanted to make sure she understood as much as possible. Once these things got going, there usually wasn’t a chance for reflection.

Professor Quantum tilted his head in agreement. “My best guess would be it’s a remnant of their culture too sacred to disregard, while also deeply inconvenient to the act of world-conquering, so they honor it in a cursory fashion. Whatever the case, no one sets a time limit that short and plans a grace period.”

No point in wasting her window, then. Lodestar did one last equipment test, checking her communicator, Professor Quantum’s newest galactic translator, the long-range scanning goggles, and other tidbits that helped make her job easier. Everything came back singing, as she’d expected. Professor Quantum had a lot of traits that caused friction between the two of them; his dedication to the work was never among them.

“This is Lodestar. Preparing to initiate contact.”

“Lodestar, we’re reading you loud and clear. Good luck, and godspeed.”

The voice on the other end represented one of the countless support staff who would be monitoring her feed, along with that of all the other active superheroes, as they tried to keep this situation contained. With a clock



ticking down and all her prep work out of the way, there was only one thing left to do.

Lodestar leapt into the air, defying gravity like she took pleasure in it, which was accurate. In the ceiling, she slipped through one of the hatches designed for expressly this purpose. When the world *needed* Lodestar, it was often time sensitive, so after the tenth roof she'd burst through, the new design rule was to leave her some escape options.

Once clear of the AHC's base, she rose up, higher into the sky. Ridge City spread out below, a beautiful tapestry of roads, homes, businesses, communities—a society of people going about their lives. As she rose, Lodestar could pick out familiar landmarks: her own home, currently empty as Penelope waited elsewhere, watching the television to see her mommy fly. Without meaning to, her eyes swept further out, to the under-construction lot that was Ivan's house. More locales filled her vision: Penelope's favorite yogurt shop, Mr. Bando's karaoke bar, and a small patch of seemingly inconsequential street not far from downtown where a significant punch was once thrown.

Rising higher, more of the world came into view. Human eyes could never have taken it all in, but Lodestar was decades past being human. She could see most of her home nation, from the quiet hamlet of Canple, where her first life had started and ended, to the bustling metropolis of Faucet Hills, where she learned to be a cape. So many places, where she'd fought so many dangers. Higher and higher, until she was past the atmosphere, out into the true vacuum of space.

She loved this spot. In the early Lodestar days, before she learned to completely control her abilities, it was her quiet place. Up here, with the right angle, it was like she could literally hold the entire world in her palm. It would be so much easier to protect that way. Sometimes, she liked to imagine a version where things were that simple. Today wasn't about peace, however. Someone had gone and parked a fleet of warships much too close to her relaxing place for Lodestar's tastes.

Time to give them a proper Earth greeting.

Just as she turned, Lodestar caught a flash from below—that would have to be trusted to the other superheroes. She had a deadline to beat. Flying over to the mothership, Lodestar scanned for anything that seemed like it might be a docking port. While she could survive the crushing void

of space without issue, not every species fared so well, and ripping a hole in their ship was a bit extreme before the fight had officially started.

Near what she thought of as the top of the pseudo-yarn ball, Lodestar spotted what appeared to be a large opening with some sort of energy barrier in front. Trusting that to be for keeping space out rather than ships or visitors, she set course and soared through, causing a commotion of surprised noises from the various Wrexwren gathered in what looked like their version of a hangar.

It was her first time seeing a Wrexwren, and they were certainly a sight to behold. Much like their ship, there was no real front or back: four huge arms, four squat legs, a thick torso, and heads without any visible features, all completely covered in what appeared to some sort of natural armor. It was sort of akin to stone, except far shinier. They began to speak to each other hurriedly, platelets in the armor of their face opening and closing quickly to create shrill tones that her translator picked up perfectly. They were surprised, but not flabbergasted.

“Somebody called for a champion from Earth. I’m here to take up the fight.”

More tones, though with less panicked energy. After a few moments, a new Wrexwren stepped out from an archway. This one was larger than the others, his armor a dark hue with spiked sections poking out. Perhaps it had to do with their roles in the society, or maybe genetics was as fickle a mistress on other worlds as it was on Earth.

“You are the Lodestar.” The voice didn’t come out of the face, which made the same tones as the others. It had a small blue device ringed around its neck, and that was where the words originated from.

“Guess my reputation precedes me,” she replied. “May I ask your name?”

This time, there was a delay between the whistles and the translator, as if it were processing. “My true name is unpronounceable in your tongue. The closest translation would be Salvryn, and I am the Zerle of this vessel.”

“Got it. Nice to meet you, Salvryn.”

Two of the arms sort of... shimmied, in a way Lodestar had no idea how to interpret. “A name is a thing given to all. I hold no pride in it. Zerle is a title of great honor. I will not be addressed without it.”

“My apologies, Zerle Salvryn. Your culture is a new one to me. I meant no offense.” Evidently, shaking arms indicated annoyance; that was

probably a good note to file away. For now, she had to play nice. No matter how obvious their intentions were, she wouldn't give them an excuse to start anything.

"Of little matter. You will follow. Time runs short." Zerle Salvrin motioned for Lodestar to come with him, moving with surprising grace for those stubby legs. She also noted that his fingers had claws, a distinction from the other Wrexwren visible; one more feature to mark him as dangerous.

Walking through the ship was bizarre, even by Lodestar's extraterrestrial-vehicle standards. Riddled with loops and repeated sections, it was akin to a maze of mirrors, only without actually needing any mirrors to function. When Zerle Salvrin finally came to a halt, however, it was not in some reinforced room, as Lodestar was expecting. Instead, they appeared to be at a communications station, based on the number of screens and flickering holograms.

At her arrival, nearly every other Wrexwren filed out, until it was only her, Zerle Salvrin, and a few other Wrexwren that also had spikes on their armor. His clawed hands began to tap at the screen.

"Before you formally accept this challenge, you should know that leaving once it begins is akin to a forfeit. Should you flee, for any reason, the victory goes to the Wrexwren."

Without warning, the other Wrexwren let out a high-pitched tone. There was no translation in her ear for that one, which meant it was probably just the sound of them cheering.

Something was off, that was obvious by now. The hidden package they were towing, the specific condition, all of it was part of a plan. Unfortunately, she didn't see any way around it. Her only option was to be strong and fast enough to neutralize their scheming.

Zerle Salvrin kept right on clicking as he talked, laying out the question like a hunter setting down steel jaws. "Knowing that, do you, Lodestar, accept the role as Earth's defender?"

"Objection!" This was not a Wrexwren voice, or Lodestar's, but it was one she knew quite well. Half-surprised, and then surprised at the fact that she *was* surprised, Lodestar turned to see the unmistakable form of Doctor Mechanial in full meta-suit strolling up casually, with Xelas on his heels. Thinking back to that flash from below, she realized they must have been flying a ship that launched only a few minutes behind her. "That message

you sent out made the invitation to any of Earth's citizens. Who says Lodestar gets to take the job just because she was here first? It's our home, too, you know. We do have a stake in this."

Several of the other Wrexwren moved position slightly, the most active one suddenly finding a seared patch of flesh roasting on his arm. Across the communications station, Xelas wiggled a still glowing finger. "Ah-ah-ah. We came here nice and chummy, playing by your rules. I'd be very certain of myself before deciding you want to play by ours."

Zerle Salvrin held up one of his four fists, and the other Wrexwren relaxed. "Very well. Do you wish to challenge her for the right? If it is not settled by the time limit, then Earth will have no defender."

"Me?" Doctor Mechaniacal put a hand on his metal chest, causing a clang. "Oh no. I'm not much of a fighter, especially not compared to these two. But I like a *good* fight, you see. One with real stakes and effort. Having you spring this on Lodestar and send her flying off would have killed all the fun." With one motion, Doctor Mechaniacal hit a button on his suit. A holographic image suddenly bloomed from a light in his hand.

The creature was massive and hideous, like a giant mouth hooked to a long body with various limbs stretching out, none quite like the others. "No idea what this thing is called, but I've been able to figure out quite a bit of other information. It appears to survive on plasma, and based on the energy readings of what they've been using to lure it along, my guess is it's the sort one finds in stars. Seems to eat every signal and light we shine on it—that's why it stayed hidden, like a living black hole."

Doctor Mechaniacal's words felt like tumblers clicking into place. A threat she couldn't ignore, even with the stakes established, one so powerful that Lodestar was the only person who might be able to stop it. But bringing in something to eat their sun? That was beyond invasion. They were willing to leave this world as nothing more than a cold husk.

"Is it who I think?" Lodestar didn't look at Doctor Mechaniacal. Her eyes were still on the monster, one that was flying not nearly far enough behind this very ship, heading toward the Earth's sun.

"Indeed, and he will be along shortly. We had him make sure the hangar was closed to any other potential interruptions."

"You have ruined our surprise, but it matters not," Zerle Salvrin declared. "Earth's hero must still choose. Defend your world from us, or from the Scralthor. Time runs short."

It was hopeless. She knew that already. The die was cast, and there would be no going back, but she still had to try. Lodestar saved people. It was who she was. “Listen to me, Zerle Salvryn. Whatever you think you’re doing, you’re wrong. I know how this sounds, and it must seem like prey in a trap begging for its life. But you are the one with the jaws closing in. While there’s still time, send that creature away. Sit down and talk with us as visitors, not invaders. Please, you have no idea what you’re getting your people into.”

This time, the pitches oscillated, high and low, long and short. Without fully understanding how she knew, Lodestar was certain she was hearing the Wrexwren version of laughter. “Pathetic. We’d been warned to no end of how dangerous Earth’s great champion is, yet she merely begs.”

Being a superhero was as much about accepting limits as challenging them. Lodestar couldn’t be everywhere, couldn’t do everything. Sometimes, she had to make the hard choices, and this was no exception. Shaking her head, she turned from Zerle Salvryn. “Remember, this was the path you wanted.”

The footsteps came from the same hall as Doctor Mechanic and Xelas had. This entity had no desire to sneak, however. He came strolling in, knocking a few globs of green-blue blood from his hands. It had been a long time since Lodestar saw the full outfit—as much as one could call it that. There had never been much of a formal costume: dark clothes, sometimes a leather jacket tossed on, an ensemble built for function over fashion. There was no need to glitz up the outfit when the mask already stood out so well. Blood red—because in the beginning, it had been actual blood; even his disguise referenced the sort of mess his fights had left behind. The eyes were still normal, but she’d seen the trick enough to know that they could change at a moment’s notice.

Her breath caught in her throat. When Lodestar asked if it was who she expected, she’d meant Pseudonym. This was so, so much worse. What happened with Apollo was one thing, losing control in a fit of rage over his children.

If Ivan had donned that mask in advance, it was a declaration of intent. Walking past, too aware of the clocks on them both, Lodestar whispered as lightly as she dared. “If there’s any mercy to be shown, try to find it.”

“They had their chance for mercy. Now, they get me.”

Roughly the answer she'd expected. Which meant her only option was to go deal with the Scralthor fast enough to still make a difference here. Not an easy task by any means, but being the strongest superhero meant Lodestar got the hardest jobs. As she flew away, back through the ship and out of the now wrecked hangar, Lodestar wasn't quite quick enough to miss Doctor Mechaniacal's words.

"My dear extraterrestrials, and the countless millions watching this stream at home, allow me to present Earth's defender for this duel: Fornax."

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## Chapter 103

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“There’s something up.” Beverly couldn’t say exactly why the sensation was there. It was no singular element, no suspicious figure walking past the same alley three times, nor covert whispers being traded by unsavory characters. She couldn’t put her finger on it, but it felt like there was too much foot traffic around them, given what was happening. And she was pretty sure *some* of the faces had repeated. Then, there were the oddities, like a man in a full suit trying to hide what looked like neck tattoos, and the businesswoman whose dress showed the telltale outline of a knife. Part of her brain whispered for her to ignore the hunch, but her family had long ago taught her that intuition was often your gut being smarter than your head. Always worth at least a listen.

“You think?” Tori said, eyes wide as she sat next to Chloe on the couch. “Not only is Doctor Mechaniacal streaming a live feed of their assault on the Wrexwren, motherfucking Fornax just walked on-screen. What the living shit are they up to?”

Beverly kept her eyes on the street, watching the way the people flowed. Less than half an hour prior, a new link had appeared all over the internet, popping up on major sites as well as social media. The stream kicked on with a spaceship like four tied-together balls showing up on screen, and from there, the viewership had only begun to soar. Enough that it was strange so many people apparently had business around their building when there was a live invasion-attempt to watch.

“Show of force. When the AHC came for us, we lost some cred. Being hauled out into the street like that, losing our anonymity—it made us seem

weak. I'd guess that's why the rules are getting pushed more. The Council wants to turn that trend around." Beverly craned her head, still focused on the street as she spoke.

"Got it." A dark joy spread across Tori's face. "We're going to remind them that the secrecy and systems were never the reason they should be afraid of us. Can't imagine a better messenger for that job."

There was a loud crunching sound as Chloe helped herself to a handful of popcorn. "At this point, anyone fighting for the same planet where I live is good with me. Go Team Earth!"

No question about it: Beverly was seeing more groups massed up as they walked by. Whatever was going on, it was escalating. Technically, there were several other buildings, other apartments, that this trouble could be addressed toward. If only that damned intuition would let her believe it.

"Tori, I know what we said about waiting until the aliens moved, but you might want to at least get in costume, if not your full suit."

To her credit, Tori's response held no hesitation. "On it. What's up?" She was already moving toward her room, where both outfits were waiting.

Beverly moved the curtains slightly aside, noting the way a select few of the walking masses reacted. Some of them had noticed, which meant they were watching her right back. "Not sure yet, just looks like trouble."

"Here I thought we rookies were going to miss out on all the fun." Tori slammed the door behind her, hurrying to change.



Lozora was learning it was hard to control a collection of individuals; they were far less cohesive than an actual group. Unfortunately, when one was hiring freelance violence, package deals were harder to come by. That was why her employer had procured a great deal of individual talent—more than really felt necessary to scare a few metas. Most of them were competent, mercifully, even if it had required hours of dressing to make them passable for normal civilians.

It was important to get the timing right. They had to strike during the initial wave, when chaos would be the highest. Even their long-laid preparations—the blocking technology in place, the teams ready to cause distractions elsewhere—would only work during the right window of



opportunity. Move too soon, and too many capes could be brought in for assistance. They needed to wait until resources were at their limit before the trap would be ready. All of the work that had been done—drawing in the aliens, testing the equipment, even tipping off the guild to move Fornax off of Earth—everything was in service to this singular goal. Lozora didn't care about the outcome in a personal sense. This was her employer's grudge entirely; her motivation was largely monetary.

Although, it would be a lie to say she was in it for the cash alone. After seeing what her fellow villains had begun, their sad little clubhouse with its long list of rules, the idea of setting a counter-example appealed to her greatly. This was a chance to remind the world what true villains looked like.

Killing several capes would be the perfect way to drive such a message home.



More high-pitched notes, laughter, coming from the Wrexwren. Zerle Salvrin made one motion, and the noise came to an instant halt. He was a commander in total control of his ship; there was no question about that.

“This is your choice? Be certain. Once he dies, your only hope is lost. Pick someone strong, and do not mistake the crew you have encountered as a sample of what you are to face.” Zerle Salvrin drew himself up to full height, which was quite impressive, and stretched those spiked limbs out. “I have endured many battles, forged my strength in the deadly terrains of untold planets. You do not fathom the danger I represent.”

Another round of laughter—only this time, it wasn't the Wrexwren. Xelas, showing the reason Doctor Mechanial had likely brought her along, was leaning on a wall, letting out peals of howling laughter. “Oh my god, you have to stop. I'm going to pee, and I don't even do that.”

Doctor Mechanial kept to the more professional approach. Reading a species without faces wasn't easy, but the way some arms crossed and bodies shifted, they didn't seem to be fans of mockery when it was turned around. “Our selection is adequately strong.”

“Very well then, we formally accept your challenge.” Zerle Salvrin tapped one button on a nearby console, and suddenly, the ship rumbled

slightly. “Should you defeat me, the invasion will be halted.”

A long pause filled the silence of the ship, until Doctor Mechanial finally piped up. “Are you waiting for us to cry out in surprise? Something like, ‘Oh no, they’re going to attack until you win, splitting your focus during the bout,’ or other tripe? Happy to disappoint, but we counted on that from the start. Before Lodestar stopped us, humanity had a real passion for making war. The ships are impressive and the discipline is respected, but you’re nowhere near humans when it comes to the mindset of combat.”

That earned some low pitches from the assembled Wrexwren, but Zerle Salvrin sounded unmoved. “All you have shown me so far is your talent for empty boasting. Come, Fornax. Let us see what the defender of Earth is capable of delivering. Your attendants may wait here, out of the way.”

“One moment.” Doctor Mechanial reached into a suit compartment and produced three small orbs. Each one glowed and quickly flitted out of his hand, hovering in the air, taking up a gentle orbit around Fornax. “I presume there are no objections to broadcasting the bout? Since you expect to win, it will be an excellent way to break the spirits of those watching below.”

“Or be a source of inspiration if I fall. A transparent effort, but I will win, so it matters not.”

It was a very good thing no one could see Wade’s actual smile. It would have given away the game right then and there. “Your grace is greatly appreciated.”

That earned him a short, shrill tone with no translation, probably akin to a grunt. Zerle Salvrin left the room with Fornax in tow, walking him along a stretch of various paths and routes, all of which were recorded and mapped by Doctor Mechanial as the cameras followed. It required fiddling with lots of settings and unseen screens, so to an outsider, he might have appeared to be pawing at empty air. Even if it left him looking silly at times, Doctor Mechanial still preferred this to display screens others could see, largely for situations precisely like this one.

While Fornax was being led away, he made a few motions not related to any camera work. No, these had more to do with the ship’s systems as a whole, and the remote access module Xelas had planted on their way in. It had taken a lot of work and every ounce of extraterrestrial tech information they could get a hold of, but as the connection established, Doctor

Mechaniacal felt a deep satisfaction ripple through his bones. There was truly nothing like the feel of a plan coming together.

Access was only the first step, however. There was still quite a bit of work to do before the real scheme could kick in. Until then, Fornax, and Earth as a whole, were just going to have to endure.



Against the dark backdrop of space, it was easy to spot the hundreds of smaller ships alighting out of the fleet, their first wave of attack heading for the surface. Lodestar wanted to turn back, to knock them all from the sky before they could ever touch down, but she had *much* bigger concerns. The Scralthor, as Zerle Salvryn had called it, still looked mostly like a dark patch of space to Lodestar, but with every passing moment, she was catching more and more details.

Huge was an understatement. This thing could have easily tossed a comet without thinking twice. Its motions were like living ink on a map of the stars—it was more emptiness than being. Leading it by some distance, she spotted a pair of Wrexwren ships, spitting out small sprays of what appeared to be glowing liquid. Bait, meant to lure it closer to its targets. This close, there couldn't be much more guidance needed. Not for a creature that had evolved to eat stars. Most predators had means of finding their prey.

In earlier days, Lodestar would have been awash in self-doubt, wondering if she had the necessary power to defeat this threat. Having enough strength was no longer a fear she held, but wielding that power appropriately was another matter. For all she knew, this was a sentient, thinking creature that had merely been led to destruction by the Wrexwren. Just because something looked scary didn't make it evil. Using the kind of power it would take to stop the Scralthor came with risks; she'd much rather convince it to change course.

Should that fail, then force would be resorted to—hopefully just enough to scare it away before she had to get serious. So many steps to get through, and all while the Earth was fighting off an invasion. At least they weren't unprepared for it. If the Wrexwren thought her planet had put all of its eggs

into the dueling basket, they were in for a sun-eating-sized shock of their own.



Across the world, skies burned with the glow of alien ships breaking through the atmosphere. For some, they came out of clouds, ruining a blue-sky day. Others saw their strange curves descending under moonlight. Citizens of all walks of life, in nearly every country, felt the tight clamp of fear bind their chests as the invaders landed around the globe. That terror drove some inward, deeper into their safehouses and bunkers to ride out the storm. For a different sort, rage was hot on fear's tracks, a fury borne from the fact that some interloping bastards would come try take this planet.

Wrexwren ships began to touch down; the first reports were already hitting the internet. The crews emerged clad in a foam-like exterior that was evidently their spacesuit, swinging strangely shaped objects that soon proved to be dangerous weapons. For a terrible moment, it felt like a true invasion, as though the aliens might get a foothold it would be impossible to drive them out of.

Lozora cared for none of that. Her orders were simple on this front. Now that the Wrexwren were beginning to move, the AHC was reacting. The digital feed scanner showed her capes suddenly popping up in all corners of the Earth. The Wrexwren invasion had officially, finally, kicked off. With their giant smokescreen in place, it was time to get to work on their actual objective.

"Listen up, everyone. I want to be crystal clear on this: the goal is to make them afraid. Corpses do not help us. Unconscious bodies, do not help us. Mutilated leftovers... well, that one is probably circumstantial, but we are not going to risk it." Lozora looked at her crew, the hodgepodge of miscreants her employer had managed to recruit. She'd have liked some heavy hitters, even one other Rookstone escapee, more for their experience than power. Half of this lot looked like they'd start slicing and never look back once they had a target.

"To put as fine a point on this as I can, anyone who breaks that rule can expect to have a long session with me, and Mr. Worthington, when this is over."

Even the hardest of faces blanched at that. There was an aura to the man, a coldness that went deeper than any she'd seen before. It wasn't that he was strong—that was common enough in the meta-human world. It was that he had an unmistakable mix of ruthlessness and competence. Encountering someone who claimed they would do anything to see their goals met wasn't a total rarity, but meeting someone who actually seemed capable of following through on such schemes was another matter. Her employer was such a man, and she was quite curious to see how one of his plans looked when it came to fruition.

After months of work and laying low, she was starting to feel like a proper criminal again. An excellent sign, since the day was only just getting started. Lozora gave one last look at the building, then back to her stitched-together crew.

“Remember: above all, we want them scared. Afraid for their very lives. So terrified, in fact, that they're even willing to call the capes for help.” Once the real targets showed up, that was when things would get interesting.

With a nod, Lozora dismissed her crew, and they moved toward the building as one. No more need for skulking about, hiding, or subtlety. At long last, it was time for a fight.

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## Chapter 104

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“They’re coming.” This time, it was Tori who gave the report, though only barely. Between the full mask and costume, along with nearly every piece of her meta-suit, she was as close to being Hephaestus as possible without fully making the switch. Sitting at her side rested her helmet, waiting for the moment when it was donned.

On her laptop, she could see the crowd moving through the remote camera feeds they’d set up. With limited time to work in, most of their preparations had been focused on expanding their information-gathering capabilities. A few traps were waiting as well, but they’d all been built with the intention of halting robbers, or perhaps a few rogue aliens. As things stood, they were facing dozens of enemies, and with their civilian disguises falling away, it looked like at least some had experience with violence.

“Best guess on what they want?” Beverly had also changed, her usual flair for fashion replaced by the thick armor that would shift with Bahamut’s various dragon forms.

“This feels like the kind of force you’d see for guild business, except I can’t think of anyone we’ve pissed off enough to warrant the effort.” Tori paused, thinking things over. “Well, no one still around, or who has these kinds of resources.”

Clad in combat boots, thick pants, a flak jacket that Beverly had produced without explanation, and of course, holding her pink and black umbrella, Chloe was pacing around in the back, thinking hard. Her face was mostly covered by a wool balaclava, with a set of Tori’s telescope-goggles added to obscure her eyes, yet one could still make out the worried lines of

her forehead if they searched carefully. “Maybe they’re friends of that gang who kidnapped you and got slaughtered?”

“Publicly, that was on Nexus. Privately, on the guild. Either way, I’d be a weird retribution target. Not impossible, though.” Something snagged in Tori’s brain, a memory from that dark time when she’d been taken against her will. “But that gang never wanted me in the first place. I was just bait, put in a trap to lure the New Science Sentries out, because they thought Tachyonic and I were an item.”

“Which many people online still do,” Beverly pointed out.

Finally, they’d hit an angle that had even the smallest bit of legs. Tori watched as strangers moved toward the building steadily, methodically, ensuring every exit was covered. The crowd didn’t even care how visible they now were. Definitely not the actions of people who were walking in expecting a fight. If she was right, that definitely meant they were here for Tori, not Hephaestus. What they would find, now that was a matter still to be decided.

Tapping carefully at a key with her gauntlet-covered hand, Tori cycled through the camera angles once more, getting a full sweep of the area. “Whether or not this is about the New Science Sentries, I don’t think they know who they’re coming for. Maybe they want to make enough commotion that Agent Quantum and the others show up; maybe they’re here to kill the whole building. The question is, what are we going to do? If there’s running to be done, this is our prime chance. They can show up to find an empty apartment.”

There was a look on Beverly’s face that Tori was starting to learn. It happened when they hit a point where her life and her nature were forced to be at odds with one another. The truth of the matter was, Beverly didn’t have the right disposition for villainy. She was too nice, too responsible—only her absolute hatred of the AHC had kept her from viewing the other side as an option. As a result, Beverly was caught in a difficult situation: trying to live as a villain while still being true to the decent person she was.

“We aren’t the only ones who live here.” It was Chloe who put voice to the issue, briefly changing Beverly’s expression to one of relief. “What if they find us gone and burn the whole place down, or we’re not even the targets?”

“Besides, you really want those pieces of shit touching all your stuff?” Beverly added.

The smart move, the survivor's move, was to leave now. Use Chloe's power, get out of Ridge City, spend the invasion holed up in some backwater bar, watching it all play out on television. The villain's move, on the other hand, would be to obliterate her would-be attackers, sending a message to all who tried next. Prey, or predator. Tori had fought like hell to claim the title of villain. It was time to start defining what that truly meant for her.

"We're going to use Chloe's power," she announced. The faces of both her colleagues were momentarily disappointed, though the expression changed as soon as she wrapped one armored hand around her helmet. "We're just going to use it a little differently than originally planned."



As the Wrexwren landed, out came the orders: different parts of the city, suddenly flaring up with various issues. The more experienced superheroes were sent to handle the actual landing sites, while Cyber Geek and his team ran to clear rubble from the road. A nearby building had been clipped by a landing ship, causing a massive obstruction in the roadway.

Medley and Cold Shoulder teamed up to haul the debris, the latter in her giant ice-armor to make lifting easier. Hat Trick was directing traffic around them, and as for Cyber Geek himself, he was making use of Autom's Eye from the latest *Sneak Soldiers Semi-Solid* game. In a franchise built around stealthing into various places and bases, there was no shortage of useful goodies to play around with, and this one was a real doozy, capable of floating through the air, scanning within set parameters, even feeding the images back into his eyeball display. Thanks to Autom's Eye, he was able to note that there were no Wrexwren approaching their position, though the humans nearby were getting antsy.

"Cyber Geek, what's your status?" The voice came over his communicator, one of the support staff that was too numerous to learn purely by voice.

"Cleanup is nearly complete, at least for the big chunks. Team is ready for our next assignment."

"We've got reports of an unusually large crowd massing up in a residential block to your east. Could be people collectively banding together



in case they're attacked, but the old lady who called it in sounded spooked. Better make sure we don't have early rioters striking in the chaos. Sending location."

On his camera feed, Cyber Geek saw a Wrexwren wander into frame, directly to their northwest. His whole body went cold, the understanding that the battle was near landing on him in a way that seemed perhaps too familiar, given how long he'd been at this. It was a small mercy that the Wrexwren arriving were nowhere as intimidating as Zerle Salvryn, the leader whose face and name were all over the internet thanks to that livestream. Why in the hell the villains were up there, let alone squaring off with the Wrexwren, he hadn't the faintest idea. There was no time to sit and watch the unfoldings, so all of his intel was coming from what could be gleaned from short snippets of information.

Quick as the threat had arrived, it vanished, punched out of frame by someone wearing a brilliant emerald cape. With a small breath of relief, Cyber Geek activated the team channel on his communicator. "Be aware, there's some extra threats to the north. Exilor has got it handled from what I can see, but still, stay careful. There could be more around. Our orders are to head east—we've got a crowd that apparently needs controlling. We're not sure if they've just scared or up to no good, so diplomacy first until we know for sure. There's plenty of people afraid right now, the last thing we need is a misunderstanding."

Medley dropped a sizable hunk of bricks onto the sidewalk, out of the roadway, before spinning a few times to get his bearings. "You said east of where we are now?"

"Yeah, why?"

The buzz on Cyber Geek's phone proved to answer the question at the same time as Medley did, even though his teammate couldn't see the mini-map that had just appeared, showing their next destination.

"I'm pretty sure that's where we went to your friend's pool party."

Whether it was his animal abilities or merely a good sense of direction, Medley was spot on. While the map only gave a general zone based on the report received, it couldn't be a coincidence that Tori's building was smack dab in the middle of the estimated area.

"Everyone, move out. We've got civilians in potential danger." Despite keeping his words calm and professional, it took everything Cyber Geek had not to put on his jetpack at that very moment. Getting there ahead of his

team would only make things harder, however, and rationally, he knew that. Nevertheless, after failing to be there for Tori twice already, Cyber Geek refused to go for three.

This time, he was going to save his friend.



“Get me every space-faring meta we have up there, knock those ships down before they ever break the atmosphere. Defense team, why are our beam-cannons missing so many of these vessels? How is our ground response going?”

From the sea of nameless workers, a voice rose up. “We’re working on counters for some of shielding and blocking tech they’ve employed, sir, but it’s... well, it’s like they know exactly what to defend against.”

Professor Quantum stood in the center of the chaos, watching every monitor, hearing every tidbit screamed or spoken his way, constantly calculating. In terms of raw power, he was now on the higher side of the scale, although he’d started much closer to Agent Quantum before decades of self-betterment. Even after all of that, his physical capabilities could never hold a candle to the talents of his mind. The world was filled with metas of all shapes and manners, but only he, only Professor Quantum, had gotten there on his own. He’d broken the world, yes, and by doing so introduced the meta-elements and shifted physics that made such impossibilities real, but he’d had to do it before those things existed. His power had come through old-fashioned hard work and genius, traits that were only amplified after the change.

Today, he was acting as the nerve-center of the response, issuing orders and tactics, conducting the entire fray like a lab-coat wearing maestro. Out there, he was one more set of highly capable fists. In here, he was an electric charge to the system, speeding everything up and handling issues as they arose. No one had objected to him taking on the role; in fact, most were delighted by it. Even Lodestar agreed it was the right call, and they were so often at philosophical odds that alone counted as a small miracle.

Yet it was not entirely for the greater good of the AHC that Professor Quantum had taken his place in the communications hub on this occasion. Somewhere, in the deepest recesses of his brain, a small voice whispered

that he should see as much as he could. This tiny, oft-ignored voice represented what remained of Professor Quantum's self-doubt—a voice that whispered there was *one* enemy out there who could have been at work behind the scenes. Thought to be dead, but then, wouldn't be the first time, would it? With his massive intellect absorbing every detail from the multitude of informational streams, this ensured that if any clues did pop up, Professor Quantum would be the one to catch them first.

How he would deal with such an issue if it arose remained to be seen. There would be situational details to consider, but Professor Quantum would want to have a hand in the response regardless. If that annoying little voice did prove to be right, it only be proper that he deal with it.

This was no mere common criminal capitalizing on an opportunity. This was a chance to deal with an old friend.

For good.

At long last.



It was hard to tell if he was being led purposefully on a long route, or the winding nature of the ship simply made it seem that way. Around Ivan the orbs swirled, sending video of him and Zerle Salvrin, still leading the way, back home to Earth. The broadcast idea had been a hard sell, but Wade won out in the end. As he pointed out, the purpose of this was visibility, reminding everyone why the guild was nothing to trifle with. If they allowed the AHC to control the narrative, then any achievements the guild earned would either be minimized, ignored, or outright robbed of their due credit, depending on what suited the organization best. This way, there was no chance for them to spin. It gave the guild control of their own message, but also demanded Ivan rise to the challenge of live theatre. Fornax's performance would be key to making this worth the effort.

Zerle Salvrin made no attempts at chitchat or conversation. If Ivan was reading his general energy right, the Wrexwren leader seemed more put out than anything. Likely, he'd expected to join the invasion fun once Lodestar was off handling the giant space-monster. One of great many disappointments Ivan planned to deliver before the day was over.

At last, they reached a pair of large doors covered in various markings. Zerle Salvrin tapped a clawed finger on the entrance, producing an unexpectedly harmonious *ping*. “Perzolic ore. Very rare. Source unknown, chunks have been found spread across the galaxy. Once forged, indestructible. Every master-warship must include such a chamber. The only way to have a proper battle while traveling.”

The message was clear: no need to hold back. This cell could handle whatever they dished out—in theory, anyway. Zerle Salvrin stepped back as the doors parted and revealed an entire room made of the same gleaming metal. Given the rarity Salvrin described, Ivan could only speculate how many worlds worth of conquering this represented. Maybe there were a few shards of Perzolic ore buried on his planet as well, scraps the Wrexwren were eager to get their claws on.

He stepped inside, followed by Zerle Salvrin. Once they were through, the doors shut loudly and melodically in one sweeping clang. Scanning around, Ivan noted that there were no screens or windows—hardly surprising given the room’s purpose, but inconvenient for the plan he had in mind.

“Perhaps you technologically sophisticated pillagers have some sort of way to watch the outside world. Lodestar versus a monster that eats suns, I *have* to see that one play out.” The grin he gave was not for Zerle Salvrin; very little of any of this was. All of the pageantry was for the masses watching at home, ones who’d know quite well about Fornax’s history battling Lodestar.

“You wish to see your champion devoured before being broken yourself. What a strange challenger they have sent me this time.”

On the ceiling above them, an image suddenly snapped into focus. Darkness, the void of space stretching on endlessly... until the flash of light. Lodestar, blazing through the sky, on a crash course with an alien creature of untold size and power. Didn’t even seem fair, really.

“Do you have more requests, or are you prepared to begin?” Zerle Salvrin did little to hide his lack of patience, so perhaps the walk to get here really was just that long after all.

“I was prepared upon arrival, there—”

The movement was instantaneous, so much faster than the unwieldy size betrayed. Zerle Salvrin struck as soon as Ivan confirmed he was ready, mix of limbs twisting into a strange pretzel of crooks and angles. There was

only a second to realize that this must be a kind of Wrexwren martial art before the first blow caught Ivan in the face, blasting him across the room where he banged off the far wall, leaving not so much as a scratch in the surface. He did note that the ringing sounds were far less enjoyable when conjuring them with one's own skull.

"Pathetic." Zerle Salvryn was standing a bit back, still twisted up, waiting to see what his opponent would do. After all that boasting, Ivan was really hoping for a paper tiger; unfortunately, Zerle Salvryn lived up to his own hype. That punch had packed a *wallop*.

Rising to his feet, Ivan brushed off his shirt and ran a hand along Fornax's mask, as if checking the placement—not that it had any potential to move with all the latches and charms keeping it in place. "Not bad, for a sucker punch. You might make this fun yet."

Again, no hesitation as Zerle Salvryn charged, although he did let out one quick response before unleashing a flurry of blows. "Pity, I do not hold the same expectations for you."

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## Chapter 105

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For a bunch of randoms, Lozora's motley collection of crooks was sticking to the plan surprisingly well. They'd all remembered their approaches and areas to guard, ensuring there was no chance of escape. After that, it was a matter of turning up the pressure until the women caved and called for help.

"Boss, we got an issue. The team that was supposed to be ahead of us isn't here." The communicators, like all the tech these minions were using, were hand-made by her employer. A little shoddy on appearance, yet they carried a clear signal from within the building to Lozora's position down the street, where she was keeping watch.

The message came from one of the front-teams, second only to the actual first wave. "Are there any clues?"

"We thought we heard a scream and something heavy falling, but that's it. No signs of a struggle. They're just gone."

Teleportation? Or perhaps just a hidden pit or latch that covered up the captured contents. Either way, what the hell? Who had put traps inside an apartment building? After a moment's consideration, Lozora reasoned that there must have been defensive measures put in when the New Science Sentries took up residency.

"Careful, the AHC might have added a few tricks around there. Can't be too dangerous, though, not in a public residence. Watch where you're going, and I'm sure you'll be fine."

"Sure" was something of an overstatement, and for a moment, Lozora felt the uncomfortable sensation of guilt slither through her. It wasn't based on morality in particular—these assets were expendable, that was the reason

they were here, and she didn't tend to hold mammalian life in high regard to start. Yet she did dislike finding herself doing to others what she herself especially loathed. Keeping a team in the dark made her feel a bit too much like her employer. The man barely gave her any information to go off of, keeping nearly all the tidbits that might make her job that much easier to himself. At least they knew who the bait was versus the real target... probably.

This time, she caught part of a boom on her communicator, in the split second before it cut out. After waiting a few moments, she tapped the broadcaster to send out a wide message. "Everyone, be advised: it seems there are some traps in place. Two of our advance teams are down already."

She imagined that riled them slightly. Most had been equipped with some level of offensive equipment, although those were for when the capes arrived, making these lower-powered goons feel like real threats for a change. Only now they would start realizing that a shiny new toy wasn't enough to change the odds entirely, not in a world like theirs. There might be threats they never even saw coming, to say nothing of having time to pull a trigger.

Because of her vantage point away from the building, only Lozora saw the approach. A figure in black metal descended from the sky, coming down with unexpected grace on the sidewalk outside. For a moment, she dared hope the job might be done, only to quickly realize this wasn't the cape they were fishing for. Didn't look like any cape she knew, in fact. She might have seen a suit like that one in the Ridge City Riots footage, but who could keep track of every metal-based costume?

Regardless, this wasn't their target: only an interloper and potential cause of trouble. Luckily, that was why the pawns had been equipped. This should be a threat they could handle, with the aid of technology.

"Perimeter Team Two, there's a meta-suit that just landed near your exit. Send a few with firepower to deal with it."

Almost instantly, they came from the nearest doorway's shadows. Three of her people, all packing some manner of ranged weapon. The one at the vanguard had a red serpent tattooed along the length of his body, poking out of the neck and ending on his skull. She'd seem him bring that tattoo to life when another member of the crew spoke with disrespect; it manifested as nine feet long and incredibly venomous. And that was nothing compared to what the mini-molecule detonator he was aiming would do to all but the

hardest of flesh. Behind him were a pair of tough metas with fun guns of their own. She practically felt bad for the poor idiot who'd chosen the wrong landing point.

Running up on their quarry, they didn't bother with such pleasantries as a warning. Red Snake raised his gun, getting a line on the target, ready to shoot. Lozora was so focused on watching her people, she didn't catch the source of the beam. All she saw was the flash of light as a searing energy burst forth, sweeping along to make sure it hit all three of the approaching forms. In seconds, it was over, and what remained of Lozora's attackers was writhing on the ground.

No warning. Not even a word said. They saw a weapon aimed and responded with zero hesitation, employing what was inarguably *far* too much force. That was definitely not a cape—even the worst of them couldn't get away with that kind of response. Yet the power of the weaponry employed spoke to a professional, someone a cut above from the general rabble of ne'er-do-wells.

The only minor mercy was that, by luck or intent, the beam had been fired at a low angle, targeting the bottom halves of the would-be attackers and ensuring only some melted street in collateral damage. Lozora also noticed a lack of blood, and quickly realized that the wounds were cauterized as they formed. The end result was that all three were technically alive, for the moment, though none were as whole as they'd been moments prior.

"What the living fu—" Lozora didn't hear the rest of the message. It was cut off, though she was fairly certain her excellent ears detected something like a roar coming from within the building. More than just one, they were coming in succession. Screams, as well.

After a moment, she got a more coherent message. "Boss, something is in here! It's green, and huge, and it's breaking people in half. We can't even get a clean shot."

"Then take a dirty one," Lozora snapped. Months of work, planning, scheming, and all of it was getting immediately fucked up by some unknowns crashing the party. She didn't really care about success or failure on a personal level, but her employer would be sure to blame her for any issues, and this project represented too much work to miss out on her payday.



Like most of the crew, this member proved to be more adept than expected at following orders. Less than five seconds later, part of the building's third floor exterior wall exploded outward, sending brick and debris spraying into the empty street. The newly formed window showed Lozora a peek at what was going on, and it was not a pleasant sight. What few of her people she could even still see were either leaning on a wall or one another, clearly nursing injuries. One of them lifted a staff overhead, preparing an attack, only to go sailing back from an unseen blow. The strike carried him off his feet, and would have slammed him into a wall, if only the wall was still there.

Instead, he went sailing out the new third-story expedient exit, crashing with a wet thud on the sidewalk below. Lozora was fairly certain he'd been an extra tough meta, so there was a chance he might walk it off. The same couldn't be said for what remained of the advance teams, who'd been cut through at a rapid rate.

While Lozora was distracted, the black meta-suit had advanced, making it all the way to the front entrance. She didn't see the charge, but evidently, one of her people tried to hold the perimeter. The suit threw a punch, grabbed an arm and twisted its hips, hurling the adversary into plain view as they were tossed over the suit's shoulder, into the street. Blood ran down the goon's mouth, indicating where that first punch had landed. Walking back over, the suit leaned down, and then stomped on both of the man's elbows. Between the impact and the audible *crunch*, it was clear he wouldn't be getting back into the fray.

Much as she respected the efficient brutality, they were clipping through her pawns at a rapid rate, and the real party hadn't even kicked off yet. She was going to have to slow this down, which meant getting her own hands dirty. It would make things tougher later on, but this had to last until the cavalry was called for.

"Hephaestus!" The voice rang out from the sky, the descending form of Cyber Geek soaring into view, jet plumes firing off a pack strapped to his back. He bore down on the suit almost like he planned to crash, before pulling up short just in time, coming to a sharp halt. "What have you done?"

"Self-defense." Hephaestus, the suit's evident name, tilted their helmet down to the man still writhing in pain. "Maybe slightly aggressive self-defense."

“You call this slightly?” He motioned to the downed man, even as more were appearing from within the building, taking note of the injured among their peers.

“Look buddy, if someone points a gun at me, I’m not taking the gun. I’m taking the whole fucking arm.”

Nearly on cue, one of the rabble from the building raised an impact isolater, firing at where Hephaestus and Cyber Geek were standing. The explosion of force sent Cyber Geek flying backward, causing a flicker of blue light where he landed, while Hephaestus was merely knocked back a few paces, the differences in their mass causing variant reactions.

Two more goons had their weapons at the ready, and Lozora felt a sense of relief as things got back on track. The giant wall of ice that suddenly formed, blocking line of sight between her crew and their targets, stole the relief away just as quickly. Multicolored scarves shot out from a nearby alley, ensnaring and plucking the weapons from the attackers’ hands. A hulking beast of a creature ran over, scooping Cyber Geek up and putting him back on his feet.

“What’s going on?” Now that she could see him better, Lozora recognized Medley, along with Hat Trick and Cold Shoulder. They’d managed to summon a team of capes, as intended, just not the right ones.

“No idea. Some kind of attack, and it doesn’t seem like aliens,” Cyber Geek relayed.

Scanning the field, Medley caught sight of Hephaestus and let out a growl, stepping forward before Cyber Geek’s hand snagged his furry shoulder. “Hang on. He’s not with them. They shot at both of us.”

“Of course I’m not with them. These bastards came at me. I’m just showing them the folly of their ways.” Without warning, Hephaestus fired another beam, this one directly into the ice wall. It exploded the entire structure, turning the shards of frozen water into shrapnel flying directly at the formerly gun-toting trio. This time, there was quite a lot of blood, as jagged hunks of ice didn’t seal their wounds the way an energy beam did.

“Stop that!” Cyber Geek yelled, growing visibly distressed. “You’re going to kill someone.”

“Do you think those guns fired beams of candy canes and rainbows? Wake up, dipshit. Those people were aiming for our heads. They are not here to play the game of capes and villains. They came with a purpose and will happily leave you cold on the street if you get in their way.”

So, this suit was a man named Hephaestus, and he was observant, as well as able to comprehend the true stakes on the table. A complication, no doubt about that, yet in the end, things had still worked out well enough. The targeted woman calling for help would have been ideal, as it was the least complicated version of the plan. However, there was no reason it couldn't be multiple factors that drew the New Science Sentries over: fellow capes asking for backup would be an excellent motivator.

Double-checking her laptop feed, Lozora confirmed that the AHC's resources were largely deployed. The goal was to limit how many options could even come to help; otherwise, they might end up with more unwanted additions. Based on what their systems were able to gather, the capes appeared to be stretched damn thin. For every three Wrexwren landing sites, there would be only one unit to respond. The aliens could certainly take direction well—they were overwhelming the exceptional skills of any individual cape purely by being too numerous to be effectively dealt with.

With so much to handle, the only teams likely to respond would be other capes stationed in Ridge City. Between the location and the team needing assistance, she couldn't see any possible way to stack the deck harder for getting the New Science Sentries. Since there were no more variables to tweak, that meant it was time to advance.

“Secondary team, now.”

Had they possessed a capable teleporter, her first choice would have been to drop the additional troops in suddenly, with no warning. Since that was not a skill her employer possessed, however, they'd gone with another, more classic method. All around the street, car doors began to open and bodies poured out. Using the same cloaking tech they'd tested with the kidnappers, every vehicle had been fitted to hide any life signs from even the most potent of scans. In a night of pre-invasion revelry around town, it had been a simple matter to have them parked and waiting.

Just like that, the capes and Hephaestus found themselves surrounded on all sides. These were more formidable opponents, the ones considered to be not quite so easily replaced, and as such, her employer had gifted them with higher-valued equipment. If these annoyances thought all the fights would be so easy as the first wave, they would be in for quite the surprise.

“Come on, already,” she muttered, idly checking the streets and sky for movement. The sooner they arrived, the sooner the real work could start. One way or another, they were going to pull the New Science Sentries here.

It was just a matter of finding the screams that would bring them running.

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## Chapter 106

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Ducking beneath the cracked remains of a lamppost, Jean huddled in the shadows, hoping that the unnatural forms wandering nearby wouldn't notice. They'd already landed their ship in the middle of his block, opening fire on the nearby citizens with their strange, sizzling weapons. Jean was trying to slip out. He was the only one of his family here; he just *had* to move to the big city for University. Already, his mind was on the village kilometers away, hoping it was as peaceful and idyllic as his heavily panicked memory was recalling. He had to get there, had to make it away from the landing site. The Wrexwren couldn't be everywhere. It was just a matter of staying unseen.

The pair nearby were pawing at the front of a jewelry store window that had been smashed open in the chaos. One with armor in a light green hue plucked a sapphire earring from the display. It made high-pitched whistles to its magenta counterpart, who echoed similar sounds right back. Green took the gem in its eight-digit hand, then slammed the butt of its weapon down onto it, causing a spark. Lifting its arm high, Green dropped the chunks of sapphire down into its face, all the various holes opening wide to accept the offering.

Silence, then loud, sharp whistles as the green Wrexwren shook its head violently, clearly unhappy with the choice of snack. While they were distracted, Jean started to creep back, slowly and steadily shifting his feet one after another. Not too fast, focus on being silent. Every step had to be sure... which made the sudden arrival of the curb behind him so unfortunate.

Although he momentarily lost his footing, Jean managed to avoid taking a tumble. He didn't even whirl his arms or nearly keel over. What he did, however, was produce a loud yelp in the brief instant where he felt the ground slip out from under him. The moment his foot was stable, he looked back at the Wrexwren, whose heads were suddenly stiff and alert.

All efforts at planning flew away in an instant. Jean simply turned and ran for everything he was worth. Stubby legs slamming onto cobblestones marked the pace of his pursuers, and it was horrifyingly swift. They were catching up already as he took the first corner, using his knowledge of the area to aim for narrow, twisting alleys. If he could lose them on the angles and find a nook to hide inside, he might see that farm again one day after all.

Part of him wanted to look upward, to search the skies, wondering where the hell all the capes were at. What was the point of the AHC having a branch here if Sir Vitesse couldn't even marshal the superheroes into helping out? Jean already knew the answer, though. They were out there dealing with the hundreds of other ships that had come crashing to Earth. He'd just been unlucky enough to be one of the people left on their own.

Ducking along a narrow stone wall, Jean hunkered down, listening to the sounds of heavy steps now no longer dashing. Had he managed to lose them?

That delusion lasted only until the first nearby wall exploded in a shower of mortar and rubble. Ten feet over, and Jean would have been caught in the detonation. Through the gap, he could just make out the form of the Wrexwren. Magenta had a weapon still pointed at the wall, whereas Green was selecting a target. A sharp whistle and shifting head confirmed that the window had worked both ways; they'd seen Jean at the same time he spotted them. Not that it would have mattered, since they were obviously happy to destroy the whole neighborhood for the fun of running down their quarry.

Nowhere else to run, and little hope of superheroes happening by to offer salvation. This was it, then. To his surprise, Jean felt calmer than he would have expected; once the future became certain, fear was something of a useless concept. He started to lift his arms into fists, thin as they were, before thinking better of it. From the rubble, Jean lifted a hefty chunk of stone. It felt almost fitting, to fight with a rock, humanity's very first evolutionary tool pitted against these better-equipped sci-fi conquerors.

Magenta raised its weapon once more, making sure Jean knew he would have limited time to use that rock. Then, without any warning, the Wrexwren was gone. In its place was an exploded pile of viscera and organs, none of which appeared even vaguely human. Green was still there, swiveling its head around quickly. It very nearly got a guard up in time before the hulking man stepped out of the alley's shadows. The Wrexwren struggled as those meaty hands broke apart its attempts to block, this giant man gripping the whistling head like he was palming a basketball. A grunt of effort slipped out as he turned the arm—and the Wrexwren's head—steadily counter-clockwise. Several crunches and pops made it seem as if the job was done, but when he yanked at the end and took the head off entirely, there could be no doubt that the fight was definitely won.

"Anything fun?" The voice didn't come from the giant. It was further up the alley, and had spoken in English. Jean knew quite a bit from his studies, so he listened closely, unsure of whether this was truly better than what he'd been facing or not. Mindless murdering monsters were horrifying in their own right, but there were some truly scary humans out there, as well.

"More exploders, from the looks of things." The huge man hunkered down and lifted up the light green Wrexwren remains, gently plucking the weapon hanging from its claws.

"I'm not mad at that. These are pretty fun. Can definitely find some buyers once the dust has settled. I do hope we find something a little more special, though. One of these has to be their version of a higher rank with fancier gear." The second speaker having now stepped fully into view, Jean realized he was human—in appearance, if nothing else. Slim, cheerful, clad in a pinstripe suit, a Wrexwren weapon slung over his shoulder. That explained what happened to Magenta, at any rate.

The larger man let out a low harrumph. "I still wish they hadn't destroyed the outdoor market on entry. Such a waste."

"Tell you what, after we fence all this tech, let's pick up a case of truffles and snails or whatever," his friend replied.

Moving as slowly as he could manage, Jean backed away, toward a gap in the debris where he could squeeze past. Tempting as it was to run to these two for help, capes didn't rip the heads off opponents' bodies and then loot the corpses. Whoever this duo was, they represented a different meta-human element, one that Jean had no desire to learn more about.

Just as he was about to slip through the break, Jean looked up to see that the small man was standing over the puddle that had once been a magenta Wrexwren, watching him move. For a second, they held eye contact before Jean bolted, scurrying through a break in the debris and sprinting the moment he was on the other side.

It wouldn't be until a several hundred meters later that he would finally slow down, and only then realize that perhaps the run might have been easier if he hadn't held on to the huge rock.



Seeing the crowd rise from the cars, Hephaestus dearly wished they hadn't left Chloe, who was going by Cliché in her makeshift costume, up on the roof. The plan made sense, in theory. Since the people attacking thought their targets were trapped in the apartment, all attention was focused on keeping them inside. By repositioning themselves to the rear and staying hidden in the halls, they were able to strike from the angles no one was expecting. Unfortunately, as the second wave reminded her, they weren't the only ones allowed to get clever. She did have to wonder, who the hell was committing this much force to what sure felt like fishing for small fries?

Weapons were being pulled, and she could see several metas drawing on their abilities, including one who appeared to be absolutely sizzling with energy. Before the battle could start in earnest, Hephaestus fired off a quick shot, right into the glowing one's torso. Anyone showing off that much would be more trouble than it was worth.

While certainly not planned, the shot did turn out to be helpful. All that crackling energy exploded out from the now dead meta, striking at the others nearby and causing momentary confusion. It was an unexpected window of opportunity; the question was what Hephaestus should do with it. If she zipped up to the roof and grabbed Cliché, they could pick through the interior stragglers, scoop up Bahamut, and get clear. Of course, that would mean leaving their home, along with Cyber Geek and his team, totally undefended.

Running was always an option—she wasn't ready to give up on fighting just yet, especially not when things were getting interesting. They did need



to regroup, however.

Racing over, Hephaestus clapped Cyber Geek on the arm.

“Come on. We have to go inside. We’ll be overwhelmed out here.”

“What?” Cyber Geek had produced a large shield in a shower of sparks and numbers. He was trying to get between the crooks and the others before they recovered. “Why would you help us, and why would I trust you?”

“How about because neither of us has ever tried to kill the other, which I can’t say about any of those assholes.” Hephaestus cocked a thumb at the already recovering crowd, driving home the point. “Do you really want one more enemy in this situation when you could have an ally?”

Shots came from the goons—some bullets, some blasts of strange color, all crashing into the surroundings with various destructive effects. Cyber Geek took one right on the shield, drawing a loud beep and sparks, even as the protection held together. “I suppose that old ‘enemy of my enemy’ bit doesn’t endure for no reason. Fine, we’ll go inside with you, but if you try anything—”

“You’ll scold me and call the coppers?” Hephaestus interrupted. “Save the empty threats for someone who doesn’t know how capes work. Now, let’s get in the damn building already.”

Together, the five avoided most of the shots as they scrambled for the entrance. Too many of the shots, in fact—only Medley took a few bullets, and those didn’t even break his scales. Hephaestus had a hunch they were shooting to wound, at most. If they were still holding back even after she’d wantonly been breaking their troops, then they didn’t have whatever it was they wanted yet. More and more, the evidence was pointing toward this being about someone else, and it was hard to imagine who it could be other than the New Science Sentries.

Huddling in the mail room, Hephaestus clicked off her helmet’s outward speaker and activated it’s communicator. The device was connected to a similar model expertly woven into Bahamut’s mask. Since Cliché wasn’t a guild villain, however, she had no such equipment on hand. They’d had to improvise a little to keep her in the loop.

“Bahamut, what’s your situation? We’ve got reinforcements surrounding the building, and these look more competent than the last wave. Cliché, everything okay up there?” With the helmet speaker disabled, Hephaestus was effectively able to have a private conversation, despite all the capes in proximity.

“I’m okay, but there’s a lot of people around us.” Patching a toy walkie-talkie into their communication system hadn’t been easy, but it was also a trick Tori had lots of experience with. When it came to listening in undetected, there were few things as convenient to crack as a radio signal. Guild lines were too encoded for a direct tap, but patching a signal through her helmet and relaying it to Bahamut made the whole system more or less function, at least well enough for what they needed in the moment.

After a few seconds, the deep hush of Bahamut’s voice joined in. “Pretty sure I’ve cleaned out most of the first wave, but there’s bound to be a few stragglers holed up. Have to be careful moving around inside from here on. Where do you want to regroup?”

That was an excellent question. Their own place was out, for obvious reasons. Roof would provide easy exits in a pinch, but also opened them up to fire from a distance. Given that Cliché could get them out easily enough, there was no reason to risk that yet. Ducking into a random apartment would be the easiest move, except she didn’t know which ones would be occupied, and adding civilians to the mix was only going to make things messier. They needed somewhere safe, ideally secure, and not currently occupied.

Instantly, Hephaestus knew where they were heading. “Group up at the New Science Sentries’ apartment. If anywhere in here has extra protections, that’ll be the place, and most importantly we know it’s not currently in use. Bahamut, open the door and rough up the scene so it looks like an empty place you stumbled upon mid-battle. Can’t risk letting on that we know who actually lives there. Cliché, if you want to keep an eye on things up top, it’s fine, but get out of there if there’s even a whiff of danger.”

“So far, no one seems to have noticed me,” Cliché replied. “I don’t mind keeping guard. It’s better than watching that video stream.”

“Why, what’s going on with the video?” Had Ivan already lost control and gone on a rampage? That would be a surprise, but if he was wearing that mask again, then there was no telling what was on the table. Hephaestus was prepared for anything.

“It’s Fornax. He’s... he’s losing. And it looks like it’s starting to hurt.”

Halted dead in her tracks by the cold chill of shock, Hephaestus realized she wasn’t as “prepared for anything” as she’d thought.

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## Chapter 107

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Zerle Salvrin delivered a blow to Ivan's stomach, slipping through his guard with those twisting movements and hurling him back against the far wall. Most metals would have dented, or at least shown a scratch after so much damage, yet their chamber remained intact no matter how many times Ivan was roughly slammed into the material.

Thus far in the fight, Ivan had learned quite a bit about Zerle Salvrin's combat abilities. The alien had prodigious strength, exceptional reflexes, an outstanding capacity to read an opponent, and one could only presume durability on par with the rest of his abilities. The reason Ivan had to make guesses on the hardness of his opponent was that he'd yet to land a substantial blow.

Punch after punch, he would try to dodge, block, or otherwise counter, only to be slammed from some unexpected angle, clobbered across the room until he scrambled up and the whole dance began once more. There were times Zerle Salvrin could have pushed the attack but chose not to. Perhaps he was being cautious, making sure that Ivan didn't have some hidden tricks up his sleeve. Or, as one who'd clearly reached a level of strength which surpassed that of his peers, maybe Zerle Salvrin was merely savoring the chance to let loose against a sturdy opponent. It was a sentiment Ivan understood perfectly.

"What a disappointment." Zerle Salvrin's words were still coming out translated—whether for Ivan or the audience watching at home was anyone's guess. "The rumors of Earth's strength had me intrigued. There are whispers about this section of the galaxy, tales of exploratory forces that

vanished entirely. Yet when we arrive, what do we find? An overconfident champion and a pitiful substitute.”

The laugh that rose from his throat was not Ivan’s. It was too expressive, too mad, and much too joyous. A small drop of blood slipped from the corner of his mouth, one of the small wounds this battle had already imparted. Ivan caught it with his tongue, running the red along the stretch of his teeth. It was a very familiar flavor, one that called up parts of him he’d spent decades trying to bury. He held it back, not denying what welled up within, merely halting it for the moment. This wasn’t yet the time.

“You laugh?” Zerle Salvrin was confused, though it was unclear if he was wondering why Ivan was laughing, or if he was checking to see that that’s what the sound was.

“I do. I laugh at you, Zerle Salvrin. I laugh at your idiocy, your ignorance, and your pride. I laugh because you still have no idea where this is going. And I laugh at your pitiful idea of strength. You cannot fathom the power we’ve all been struggling against, nor how we’ve grown as a result.”

No more talking: the banter earned Ivan a fresh round of punches, this time catching him directly in the ear. He spun across the room, slapping the wall once more and sliding down. Laying there, he took a brief moment to catch his breath, eyes scanning the ceiling screen to check on Lodestar’s progress. She was getting close, tearing through space at speeds no rocket could hope to match. Still going to be a while, knowing her. Even against something like that, Lodestar would try to talk. To reason. To find a way forward that didn’t require violence. It was a habit that was easy to dismiss or mock, and there had been no shortage of capes or villains who’d done both through the years.

But silly an idea as it seemed, Ivan could never say that it was pointless. Because every now and then, she was right. There was a solution other than punching, a compromise to find where everyone could be satisfied. A spark of goodness in a criminal the world was willing to write off. She had her way, and Ivan could endure until the time was right.

For the show they had planned, they required a perfectly set stage. Until then, Ivan would have to deal with the beating and wait for his cue.



The alert in Tachyonic's ear came just as he finished yanking the weapons from a pair of Wrexwren clutches. Powerful as their tech was, once it was stripped away, they were only marginally stronger than regular humans, which was nowhere near powerful enough to hang with the New Science Sentries.

Agent Quantum brought down the first Wrexwren with a pair of punches, while the other tried to flee. A searing beam of energy caused the alien to skid to a halt, moments before Agent Quantum appeared overhead, dropping heavily down and subduing his second target.

Presto popped into view nearby; now that the threats were handled, he didn't have to manipulate from behind the scenes. "Okay, I tried again and felt like I was going to burst a blood vessel. These things are either way denser than they look or have some natural resistance to teleportation. I'd wipe myself out just shifting one, forget about popping them around."

Half-ignoring Presto, Tachyonic listened carefully to the message relay. It wasn't an official dispatch, technically speaking. But he'd put in a request to be notified if there was significant activity in a certain area of Ridge City. Based on the timestamp at the end, sending it over hadn't been high priority.

"Sentries, it sounds like something might be going down back at our off-site base. There was a report of a large crowd gathering, and a team was sent out to check on it. Nothing reported back yet."

"Which could mean they're busy dealing with the threat," Plasmodia suggested.

"Or that they were wiped out in an instant," Presto countered.

Agent Quantum looked over his team, first at the pair debating, then at Tachyonic himself. His gaze lingered there, briefly, before giving his oldest friend a knowing nod. "Regardless, we have a responsibility in that building, civilians we gave our word to protect. Our track record on that front has been frankly terrible. Seems like we've finally got a chance to do this right, so let's make sure we use it well."

"I'll scout. You relay our position shift and catch up." Tachyonic was gone so fast he imagined himself getting ahead of his own words, though that was impossible at his system's current settings. Nevertheless, he blasted through the increasingly familiar streets of Ridge City, along the nearly vacant highway, past the buildings of people hunkered down, until he

neared the downtown section stuffed with residences, including one old apartment building that now hosted a giant hole in the third floor.

Skidding to a halt, Tachyonic resisted the urge to go in swinging, especially once he caught sight of the crowd that awaited. Dozens of people, none of whom looked friendly, wielding the same cobbled-together tech they'd been picking off the street for weeks. Except, this was no selection of minor wares; every person out there was geared up with at least one device. Some had multiple. That was without counting the ones showing clear meta-powers, like the woman hovering, or the guy talking to four frogs the size of hubcaps.

"Team, we've got more than just a group out here. Looks like someone assembled and outfitted a small army—none of them alien, at least visually." Tachyonic's speedy brain zipped through the possibilities. This organized and malicious group made it seem like something that villain's guild would be a good fit for, except he didn't recognize any of the milling faces. Based on the Ridge City Riots footage, most of the guild members had existing famous careers or were fairly distinctive, none of which applied to this rabble. It could be a meta-gang out to grab territory in the chaos, but this was a strange place to try to claim, especially considering the AHC headquarters wasn't too far off. It didn't track. There was nothing about this place valuable enough to warrant such force, which meant it was more likely about one of the building's tenants.

The most probable explanation was that they were here for the New Science Sentries. If their identities had leaked and someone figured out their address, that might explain the attack force. Only... much as Tachyonic hated to admit it, they hadn't really done anything to warrant this yet. Since arriving, the vast bulk of their time had been spent dealing with low-tier muggers and goons, not the kind of people who could access armies for vengeance. There was also the chance the crowd was here for Tori, if they were connected to the other gang and had decided to hold her responsible for the slaughter, since Nexus was well out of reach.

Over the communicators, he heard an unexpected, familiar voice pipe up. "Tachyonic, did you come into range?"

AHC communicators functioned on multiple levels, and while dedicated channels to the home base and one's team were always useful, there was also value in a simple proximity system, making sure they knew when they had allies in the area.

“Cyber Geek, is that you? What’s your location?”

“Currently inside, hunkered down and figuring out what to do next. They’ve been like this for the last few minutes, penning us in but not advancing.”

Tachyonic peeked around a corner, able to carefully scan the surroundings in a fraction of the time most would need. “It’s weird. They’re all staying ready to react, but there’s no movement toward the front. Any idea who these jerks are? My best guesses were a gang out for revenge or part of that villain guild.”

“The first is possible. The second one is probably out, though,” Cyber Geek replied.

“What makes you so sure?”

“Because we’ve got two of that guild’s members here with us, and they’re both pissed about the situation.”

That lined up with what little they knew about the guild—one feature of which *was* that very lack of information. If the guild did deal with internal issues, they certainly weren’t public about it; this was exactly the kind of situation that drew AHC’s attention. The fact that Cyber Geek was stuck with a pair of villains didn’t sit well with Tachyonic, however. It was possible they were there as moles, or even the ones who’d put all of this together in the first place. He’d have liked to simply trust Cyber Geek’s judgment, but with civilians in the building too, it was best to avoid chances as much as possible.

“Which two members do you have, exactly? Knowing what they can do gives us more options. I can do some quick research while the others are on their way.”

“I don’t imagine that will be necessary. Your team is already familiar with the skills of Hephaestus and Bahamut.”

Of course—of fucking course—it would be them. Taking a moment to steady himself, Tachyonic reasoned that there were two versions of this scenario: either the villains were truly with them, or part of the attack. While the latter would be highly problematic, the flipside was that he knew those two were capable: smart, tough, and motivated to survive. If the pair really were with them for this fight, it added more to their desperately mismatched team sizes. Ten versus a small army wasn’t a lot better than eight, but it *was* an improvement.

“Any sign of our mutual friends?”

“There’s some sort of blockade between us and their room, with a few people already skewered on it. We assumed you’d put some defenses in. I’ve texted her a few times since we arrived. Seems like she and the others are sheltering in place. I warned her to keep everyone indoors and away from the windows until we give the all-clear.”

A text wasn’t as good as eyes-on, but in the current situation, it still took a huge burden from Tachyon’s mind. His charge was out of harm’s way, which meant they’d be able to take a more offensive approach to handling the issue. Once his team arrived, they could figure out a plan of attack. Because, with so many civilians in the area, evacuation was out. Even if they could get to just Tori and her friends, there were too many others to reach. Protecting this area meant driving out the threat, and based on how armed they were, he had a hunch this crowd wouldn’t respond to politely spoken requests.

“Good thinking, Cyber Geek. Let’s keep them out of this as much as possible. Now, we’ve got about five minutes before the rest of my team will be able to catch up. That’s how long we have to come up with what to do next.”



It was strange, watching what looked like a parade-viewing crowd gather up on the streets below, all with their attention on her building. Cliché peered carefully over the sides of the roof in short stints, making sure not to draw their attention. Her umbrella was clutched carefully in her left hand, ready to defend if the moment demanded. The right hand, she’d left unencumbered, which was why the sudden appearance of a revolver in her fingers was such a surprise.

Spinning around, she trained the weapon on her target, only for the barrel to start immediately shaking. What the hell good was a gun supposed to do against him?

The kaleidoscope eyes of Nexus stared back at her as he cocked his head in an almost curious manner. After a moment, he snapped his fingers.

“Forewarned is forearmed. When a potential threat approached, you got a weapon. Very clever, haven’t seen one of you use that in ages.” He paid her and the weapon no mind, waltzing to the rooftop’s edge, peering over



with none of the same caution Cliché had been employing. “Shoot if you like, but I’m not here for you. You’re almost never worth it.”

The whiplash of going from shocked to terrified, relieved to slightly offended, had Cliché’s head swimming. Lowering her gun, she dropped it to the rooftop, where it soon vanished. The umbrella, conversely, she gripped tightly, ready to swing at a moment’s notice. It would likely fare as well as the gun, but it at least had a chance of working.

“What do you mean, I’m not worth it?”

He waved a hand in her general direction, eyes still on the crowd below. “What’s the point in a power you go out of your way not to master? Where’s the thrill in seeing someone give half their effort? Entertaining as you could potentially be, I’ve seen that possibility squandered untold times, because you fear what you might become.”

Stepping slightly forward, Cliché tried to angle herself so she could keep a lookout over the roof’s edge, too; if she wasn’t keeping watch, there was no point to even staying up here. “Let me guess, this is where you tell me all my fears are ridiculous and ungrounded?”

“Certainly not. You are perceptive, with yourself, as well as others, and the potential you see is far from imagined. There are worlds where you embrace your power, plumb its fullest depths, and truly master the gifts you have been given. In some of those iterations you even manage to retain what you think of as your current sense of self. But the best of the lot, the ones I consider personal favorites, are exactly what you fear: beings cut off from the laws of reality, unbound by the same limits as the rest of the world. Sometimes, Cliché, you become an even greater monster than you can imagine, and she is *glorious*. You may be of little interest, but Edict is always worth watching.”

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## Chapter 108

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At long last, she was near enough to see, and Lodestar's stomach twisted at what awaited her. Up close—or at least as close as she could get without losing sight of the massive creature—the Scralthor was a mind-twisting array of features. The dark exterior captured and reflected the void of space, masking it near perfectly, even from the AHC's advanced instruments. Long limbs, like a mix of a spider's leg, an octopus tentacle, and a sucker mouth, stretched off the vast main body. No eyes that she could see, though it did have various plates with a slightly different reflective sheen.

The most distinguishing, disgusting feature was easily its true mouth, not the sucker-like endings on its limbs. It was easy to miss on the approach, a void within a void, the place where the Scralthor stopped reflecting space and instead embodied it. Cavernous, surrounded by endless rows of grasping teeth, seemingly with no end, that was the maw Lodestar would expect from a creature that lived by surviving off of suns. Hanging there, staring at what was closer to a celestial body than a creature in terms of mass, Lodestar was momentarily struck by the sheer impossibility of her task.

It was ludicrous—to even compare their differences as an ant versus a human drastically undersold the gap in scale. Ant versus blue whale wouldn't have even properly captured it. This was no person, or meta, or even something as grand as a natural disaster. She was gazing upon a fundamental force of the galaxy, something powerful and ancient, well beyond the constraints of what a single planet could contain.

Cupping her hands to her mouth, Lodestar let out a loud yell. She was perfectly aware that sound didn't travel through the vacuum of space under normal circumstances, but this was one more area where the limits of reality had become iffy after Professor Quantum's famous experiment. Besides, the idea of standing in this creature's path was absolute lunacy to begin with. Attempting to start a conversation wasn't really all that much more ridiculous, comparatively.

"Hey there!" Decades of this, and she never felt like she'd gotten the hang of starting the awkward pre-fight discussions. It was hard to find a cordial greeting for a being one was likely about to exchange blows with, yet she still persisted, because sometimes, those greetings were enough to keep the punches from being needed. "I don't suppose you're a talker?"

No reaction, which was more or less what Lodestar had expected. Even the ones who did eventually listen needed their attention grabbed first, and there was really only one universal method to that end. Keeping the power low, just enough to be felt, Lodestar fired off three shots at one of the limbs, which was wiggling through the sky in a very gut-churning fashion. Her shots hit their mark, but produced no reaction that she could see. Even the limb itself was unmarked. The blasts may as well have been more awkward small talk.

About what she'd anticipated; anything that was eating suns wouldn't be that vulnerable to simple energy blasts. Part of her hoped that would have been enough to garner a kernel of attention, though, and in a way, she was right. Red beams caught her directly in the torso while her attention remained on the Scralthor, pushing her back a full inch in surprise. Glancing up, she noticed the Wrexwren ships that had been leading the cosmic monstrosity were now pointing in her direction, one charging to follow the first's shot.

Moving faster than either ship could dream of tracking, she raced right past, twisting around behind the pair and letting off a shot of her own from each hand. Unlike the Scralthor, these alien crafts were not made of some nigh indestructible natural armor, a truth that was proven nicely as Lodestar sliced up their engines, leaving them both adrift until the main forces could send someone to scoop them up.

That done, she turned back to the Scralthor, which was quite easy to do, because this close, it occupied more of the space around her than less. "Just you and me now, big guy. Please give me some kind of sign that there's

sentence in there.” Her right hand was already formed into a fist, too aware of the inevitable outcome she was staring down. Still, she *had* to try. With power like hers, it was so easy to turn force into the default solution. Only by attempting to make peace could she truly be free to fight, certain that there was no other way available in the moment.

No response as the creature continued to swim through nothingness, path unchanged even as its guides fell by the wayside. So be it, then. Time to see how the Scralthor held up against direct strikes.



Of all the suit capabilities Hephaestus hadn't expected to need today, texting was proving to be the underdog MVP. Responding to Cyber Geek's—and soon Tachyonic's—rapid requests for assurance that she was okay was all that kept them from charging down the hall to confirm Tori's safety in person, which was a very good thing for Hephaestus and Bahamut. She added a line about spotty service to both of them, hoping that would buy some breathing room if they tried to chat mid-fight. Covertly responding inside her suit wouldn't be quite so easy while also battling for survival.

“At least we're in an older building, from when they made them to last rather than break safely.” Cold Shoulder was running her hands along the exposed brick wall, getting as close as she dared to the window and scoping out a view. She nearly knocked over one of several empty ice cream containers poking out of a trash can, a caloric giveaway that someone with super-speed lived here. “Want me to ice-wall over that and limit our exposure?”

“Not yet. If anyone spots it from outside, we've basically given away our position, and right now, we need the advantage of surprise.” Cyber Geek was cycling back and forth, coordinating with Tachyonic as they waited for the rest of the New Science Sentries to arrive. He'd ended up in something of a pacing circle around Austin's go-to chair, like he was trying to conjure help here faster with a slapdash summoning circle.

It was more or less the outcome they'd specifically been trying to avoid—this outdoor assemblage of assholes had managed to bait the real targets nearly into the open. Once the New Science Sentries were known to be on the scene, Hephaestus had a hunch that the rules of the game were going to

change. Everything so far had been about drawing them in. Once it was time to spring the trap, there was no more need for niceties.

As Hephaestus saw it, every plan they formed would come from one of three foundations: send away the New Science Sentries and let the siege continue, use them as mobile bait to draw away the attackers, or let them join the fight. The second option was easily her favorite, and the one she knew would be all but impossible to talk anyone into. Even if they trusted her while under this helmet, there was no way the New Science Sentries would run off and leave another team of capes surrounded by criminals, in a room with a pair of villains, along with the civilians they were supposed to be protecting. Maybe, if they knew the whole situation, it would be viable, but this was one cost of living a double life: she couldn't tell people everything she knew, even when it would be extremely helpful information for them to have.

Finishing a sweep of the perimeter, Bahamut circled back around, sidling up next to Hephaestus under a giant light-up beer display that they both instinctively knew was Ike's. Medley had been watching them both without pause, barely even blinking, and they had no lack of understanding as to why: he expected them to turn traitor at any moment. In truth, Hephaestus couldn't even say it was a farfetched concept. Her goal was to get everyone she liked through this day alive; whether or not they were fond of the meta-suit-wearing villain in the end wasn't a central part of that equation. It did mean they had to choose every word carefully, though, since these were going to be very public conversations.

"How's the fight going?" Bahamut asked.

The short answer was "bad." A small section of the helmet's inner screen was showing a muted version of the fight stream, and when Hephaestus could bring herself to look, what she saw was her mentor getting smacked around, thrown into walls, even dripping blood. Part of her kept insisting that this had to be a trick, part of some grand villain scheme, but the bright streaks of red made that idea harder to cling to. The mere fact that the Wrexwren leader could even make Fornax bleed spoke to the power in those alien blows.

"The same," Hephaestus replied finally. "I'm sure he's got a plan."

That garnered a snort from Medley. "If that's the real Fornax, then I doubt it. His whole deal was being a walking disaster. He isn't one to plan,

and sure not the sort to get his ass kicked by a lone alien. That's either a fake, or he's gone soft."

"You have—and I cannot stress this enough—absolutely no *fucking* idea what you're talking about." She was coming back at him too hard, could even feel herself doing it, yet the rage couldn't be stopped. It wasn't even anger, really, just fear. The oldest fear she had, the one she thought would never apply to someone like Ivan: she was afraid to lose a person she cared about, and the semi-parental shape of their relationship only made the ache hit all the deeper. "That's the real Fornax, and he's going to win. It's what he does. There's only one exception to that rule, and it sure as shit isn't that Wrexwren bastard."

"I'm sure he'll be fine." Hat Trick wandered over, laying a careful hand on Hephaestus's arm. The rest kept their distance from Hephaestus and Bahamut, but she seemed entirely unconcerned by their villain status. "Lodestar wouldn't have left it in his hands otherwise."

Still positioned semi-near the window, Cold Shoulder shook her head. "Didn't seem like she had much of a choice in the matter."

"When you're as powerful as they are, you always have choices," Bahamut said. "For right now, let's trust that the ones more experienced than us are making smart calls, even if we can't grasp their significance yet. Our bigger concern is the mini-army outside. With Agent Quantum, myself, and Medley on the scene, we have a good amount of heavy hitters, plus Cold Shoulder if she makes that big ice body. Plasmodia and Hephaestus can snipe for us, putting Presto, Tachyonic, and Hat Trick in flex positions. Cyber Geek, given your array of tools, I'd assume you can fill any of those roles as needed, so let's decide where we're weakest and shore things up."

Nearby, Cyber Geek blinked in visible surprise. "That's surprisingly close to what Tachyonic and I have come up with."

"I know." Bahamut tapped the side of her head, where ears would be. She seemed to realize the absence at the same time as everyone else. "Er, you get what I mean. Good hearing, even for hushed phone conversations, and it's not a hard composition to sort out."

"The bigger question is what do we do with those teams?" Medley interjected. "How do we drive off this mob while not plunging everyone on this block into a meta-brawl?"

That was an exceptional point, but thankfully, one Hephaestus already saw the fix for. "While we don't know for sure what or who they want, it's

clearly all focused on this building. If the New Science Sentries join us, it ensures that the focus stays trained here. At that point, it becomes a game of funneling them where we can and picking through. Snipers on the roofline to keep them from swarming, heavies in the halls to block their progress, and so on.”

“Too risky,” Cyber Geek replied. “Holing up while under fire is one thing, but we can’t bring a brawl inside knowing there are also civilians sheltering here, too.”

Between seeing her mentor getting beaten and feeling trapped in her own home, Hephaestus was not in a patient enough mood to deal with moral objections. This was a survival situation. “Then you get out there and scare them off, superhero. You go show us whatever power you have that’s going to send them screaming into the night. Because as far as I can tell, they’re here to do some damage, and aren’t inclined to leave. This fight is happening, Cyber Geek. The question is if it’s on our terms, or theirs.”

“That said, we do have another asset in the building, unofficially. A friend who is pitching in, and could theoretically guide the survivors somewhere safe,” Bahamut offered. “I believe a lot of the underground parking spots here are concrete-enclosed cubes, the perfect spot for hiding out from a riotous mob.”

Cyber Geek and his team looked at one another, the unspoken question so obvious they may as well have just used words. Trusting the villains was one thing; trusting the villains to handle evacuation, and with an asset they’d never even met—that was asking a lot. Especially considering that the capes believed they had friends hiding out in another room, as well.

“When the Ridge City Riots happened, we ended up having to work with a different pair of villains, Glyph and Pest Control,” Medley stated. “I didn’t like it at the time. Still don’t fully, to be frank, but I can’t say they didn’t hold up their end of the bargain. If you can be like them, then we can walk away from all of this on the same terms. But if you betray us—”

“You’ll carry a grudge that will shine through all eternity and will harass us at every turn until one or both parties are dead. Yeah, man, I’m in a guild of villains. How do you *think* the people I’m around respond to being betrayed? Our friend will get people somewhere safe; they’ve got ways of moving around and staying unseen. Will that put you at ease enough to accept the inevitable?”

Surprisingly, Cyber Geek nodded to the affirmative. “According to Tachyonic, the rest of the New Science Sentries just arrived, and the outer crowd is getting restless, starting to look at nearby buildings. We have to get their attention and keep it. Everyone ready?”

He looked around, first to his team, then to the pair of villains sharing the room with them. No one objected. They understood where this was heading and were ready to stop cowering.

“Let’s go over starting positions, then get into them as fast as we can. The New Science Sentries are going to arrive with a splash. While we wait, let’s put that free-roaming asset of yours to work. There’s an apartment near here you’ll need to start with.”

“Should be no problem,” Hephaestus confirmed. She said a silent prayer of thanks to Bahamut, who’d just made their lives much, much easier. Not only would “moving” Tori out of supposed proximity lower her chances of being caught, it came with a perfect excuse to let the texting drop. Once her other identity was expected to be surrounded by concrete, even the best phone would have trouble keeping a signal. This was a chance to put Tori out of the way and let Hephaestus have full rein.

She only hoped their efforts fared better than Fornax’s had so far.



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## Chapter 109

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The sound of Wrexwren mirth was grating on Doctor Mechaniacal's nerves, aided in no small part by watching his oldest friend get beat to hell. The experience couldn't be pleasant for anyone who cared about Ivan, yet Doctor Mechaniacal felt it all the more keenly, because it was *his* fault. While the plan had placed huge burdens on others, like Ivan, it was Doctor Mechaniacal and Xelas who were handling the most important piece. Without them, this invasion would simply end, and that would be that. The prime opportunity they'd been handed would slip away, and in a few months, they'd be dancing the same jig with a new set of challengers.

That was why he made no objection or sounds of his own as the Wrexwren let out their whistling titters at Fornax's beating. There was better use for such mental energy. Because while it appeared that he and Xelas were standing there like good little escorts, watching what looked to be an inevitable defeat, in truth, they were both hard at work. Getting access to the systems had only been the first step. From there, it was a matter of finding what they needed, running digital tests until they found the right settings, and then making sure the implementation was flawless. Given that they were working with alien technology, it was an insane idea, even for meta-genius intellect like his own.

Now, two meta-genius intellects, with years of experience and trust deepening their connection, working in perfect tandem—*that* was another story. For as rambunctious as she could be, Xelas also possessed one of the most sophisticated digital minds in existence, thanks largely to years of self-directed upgrades and improvements. With her considerable processing

power added in, the task went from “utterly impossible” to just “mostly impossible,” and those were odds Doctor Mechanical felt quite at home with. Especially considering the progress they were making.

A little bit more. Ivan just had to hang in there for a touch longer, and things would change. He hoped the rest of the guild was out there working hard in this window, because once their plan sprang, the Wrexwren would start behaving very differently. Better to grab all they could before the aliens realized the situation they were really in. At least he didn’t have to worry about most of them getting caught up in the streaming show; they knew Fornax well enough not to expect he’d really go down like this. But based on the numbers ticking by on his helmet screen, quite a few people were tuning in.

That was just as expected, and planned. Seeing Fornax lose would certainly be curious and novel enough to draw more viewers, expanding the size of their audience. They needed to set the stage well and get as many live eyes as possible on the broadcast—the AHC would definitely attempt to purge this footage once the day was done.

And really, given how horrific it would be, Doctor Mechanical wasn’t even sure he blamed them.



The small town of Kerber was nestled perfectly between two highways, so as to be convenient for neither. Once it had held a key farm road running through it, but when the new interstate came, the travel business in the town dried up. It managed to hang on thanks to stubborn citizens and enough agriculture to get by, but it would never be a major metropolis. They had no Alliance of Heroic Champions outpost, no superheroes nearby, not even a meta-human among the population. Their law enforcement consisted of a small Sheriff’s outpost, most of which was already burning.

With no real defenses, the town of Kerber had been completely unprepared when a Wrexwren ship crashed into Old Man Gaffleston’s cornfield. Four had emerged, wielding unnatural weapons and whistling in those horrific high-pitched tones. They swept like fire, destroying all they came across as the citizens fled, most holing up in the church near the edge of town.

One member of the city did not go to the church, however. Mrs. Croskey cursed her age as the uphill walk sapped her legs' strength. She pushed herself onward, ignoring the sounds of buildings collapsing and the Wrexwren whistles, even as it seemed like they were getting closer. Roots tore at her feet, nearly tripping her twice as she pressed farther into the small grove. The third time, she fully tilted over, catching herself on a nearby tree trunk, scraping her hand badly in the process.

The pain didn't matter, nor did the ache in her lungs. She had to keep going. This was the town's only hope. None of the others knew such a chance existed; they believed their only meta-residents in history had left, never to return. Only Mrs. Croskey had gotten the visit years later, along with the gift. She'd buried it away, thinking such things best left forgotten. It was an act she regretted all the more with every step.

At last, Mrs. Croskey arrived. Her thin, wrinkled hands plunged into the dirt beneath the gnarled old tree, winding into a small gap of two intertwined roots. The Wrexwren noises were drawing near. If they found her, then they found her. What mattered was the task at hand. Arms already shaking from the overall effort, Mrs. Croskey kept digging, kept hoping, until she felt the cold metal of the box she was searching for.

With the last of her strength, she yanked it out, turning the combination tumblers to their proper position, all while hearing the aliens approach. It took more struggling than she wanted, but finally, the box opened, revealing a small silver device with a single button. On it was a stylized droplet of blood, which was soon covered by the smear of the genuine article Mrs. Croskey's scraped hand left as she smashed the button down, drawing a brief light under the symbol.

It was done. She collapsed back against a nearby tree, panting so heavily it felt like she might never catch her breath. That was possible. Her body had given too much in the run; perhaps the cost would overwhelm her. It was far from ideal, yet also a chance Mrs. Croskey knew she'd been taking. Her only wish was that she knew everyone would be safe. Devices and promises were one thing, but could she really expect that after so long

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"I'm going to need some field healing. No, a civilian. That's fine. I'll go out of pocket. This one is under my protection."

It was impossible. She'd hit the button less than a minute ago—surely this was a delusion. Yet it seemed quite real as the shadow leaned over, then

crouched to look Mrs. Croskey right in the eye. In the years since she'd last seen that gaze, much had changed, but not the determination looking back at her.

"How did you get here... so fast?" The pause for breath mid-question only drove home how depleted Mrs. Croskey was.

"I've got friends who are handy at transportation, and I promised that if you needed me, I'd be here."

"The town... needs you."

That earned Mrs. Croskey a frown, along with a resigned sigh. "Fine. But keep my name out of it, if you can. I don't want them thinking it's some bit of hometown pride. Personally, they could raze this place and I wouldn't bat an eye." She leaned in, lightly kissing the older woman on the forehead. "Except I know how much it would hurt you."

She stood back to her full height, then lifted a finger. From the wound on Mrs. Croskey's hand came a small tendril of blood, which wound its way around Morgana Le Faye's finger, before shaping itself into a dagger. The Blood Witch of the villains' guild clutched her weapon tightly, then turned back to the forest.

"Now then, let's deal with the dead pieces of shit who dared to wound my favorite teacher."



Agent Quantum looked up at the roof again and frowned. "You sure you can get an angle on that? Seems like the closest point we can see would have you both dropping a good distance to the ground below, not to mention drawing attention."

"Have a little faith. This is my one trick, and I'm pretty damn good at it," Presto replied. "I'll squeak us over the edge of the roof so we don't have far to go. There's no way around the visibility part, though. If I can see it, then I can teleport there, but I do *have* to see it. Which means when we pop out, we'll be in plain view before the fall starts."

"Which is exactly why, when they do that, you and I are charging in the front door." Tachyonic was fiddling with his bracer, getting the output settings just right. Once this battle started, there wouldn't be many chances for casual recalibration, so it was important he start off properly. "I'll run

defense, you go right for the entrance. Once we're in, the roof team starts laying down cover, breaking up the crowds that charge after us. Plasmodia, you still okay getting teamed with a villain?"

She hesitated for only a small moment before giving a blonde-hair-bouncing nod. "Not ideal, but what about this is? So long as he keeps shooting at the people attacking, we'll be good. If he tries anything, I'll pop that can open and see how tough our villain is then."

The four superheroes exchanged glances once more, before looking out to the small army blocking them from their goal. It was not the first time they'd faced such a situation, if one counted training. Professor Quantum had been relentless in preparing them for what he considered to be the most vital part of superhero work: efficiently neutralizing threats. After weeks in the real world, they'd begun to understand all the gaps such training had left in their knowledge, gaps that had caused the sorts of mistakes that had put them on the wrong foot with this town. But for all their failings, the New Science Sentries still knew how to fight. Today, it looked as though they might finally have a chance to work in their element.

Slowly, one by one, the eyes all turned to Agent Quantum, their unquestioned leader. Not because he was the most dangerous, which went to Plasmodia, or the fastest, obviously Tachyonic, or even the most perceptive, a title all would begrudgingly give to Presto. Not even because he was the one chosen by Professor Quantum to head the team.

Agent Quantum was their leader because, above all else, he had their trust. They believed in him, in the way he saw the world, in the team he wanted to lead. He might not always lead them to safety—that was the price of being a superhero—but each knew he would give every drop of blood in his veins to bring them back alive, and the feeling was reciprocated.

"The time is here. New Science Sentries: attack."

In terms of rallying cries, there was room for improvement, but the results could hardly be questioned. Agent Quantum and Tachyonic burst from their hiding place, loudly drawing attention in a way no real attackers would. The plan worked flawlessly, as suddenly, dozens of heads swiveled in their direction. Worse, they didn't just turn, the faces reacted. Lit up, in fact, at the sight of what should have been a sign that the party was over. Instead, they all looked like someone was rolling in with a truck of fresh food and drink, a few actually rubbing their palms together like greedy cartoon characters.

Nearby, Agent Quantum caught sight of several raising their unusual weapons—these resembled junkyard scraps welded into roughly gun-like shapes, similar to what they'd seen on the streets lately. None of them got raised higher than mid-waist before the blur zipping through the crowd struck. Sometimes it knocked the guns away; others received swift kicks to the back of their knees to send them sprawling; and a few just got flat-out coldcocked into unconsciousness. Agent Quantum had no idea how Tachyonic was picking which target to give which strategy; perhaps he was trying all three on each person and seeing what worked. It had to be taxing. Even with his speed, there were so many opponents to keep track of.

Agent Quantum made the job as easy on his teammate as he could, weaving wide to avoid fights and focus on speed. Some confrontations were unavoidable, however, as a one-eyed man with horns along his skull tried to halt Agent Quantum's charge. Tough as he looked, a single blow to the ribs was enough to send him hurling back, and Agent Quantum realized he'd forgotten to factor his current momentum into the punch. It was stronger than needed, but had the side effect of scaring a few nearby threats, so Agent Quantum seized the opportunity and bolted ahead.

He glanced up to the roofline just in time to catch Plasmodia's legs going over the side, out of view. That meant the sniper team was now in position, and no one appeared to be reacting to the roof, so hopefully, they'd slipped by unseen. With the distraction done, his only task remaining was to make it through the front door.

Pumping his legs, Agent Quantum didn't bother hitting the next person who jumped in his way, mostly because he'd plowed over them before there was even a chance to react. Something stung his back, fluorescent yellow strings that seemed to sear wherever they touched extending from a nearby crook's arm. It was tempting to deal with, but the lone glance back showed Agent Quantum how many of the momentarily stunned enemies were recovering both their wits and their weapons, all with their attention on him.

With the top speed he could muster, Agent Quantum barreled ahead, lowering his shoulder and knocking aside a few hefty gentlemen that tried to block him with mere mass. The effect was similar to a bowling ball cleaving through pins, sending them scattering and opening up a clear path inside. Agent Quantum took it, continuing to bolt forward until he turned a corner and nearly collided with a scaly green wall.

Except, it wasn't actually a wall. It was Bahamut, the dragon who'd managed to fight him to a stalemate only a few weeks earlier. Normally, Agent Quantum wouldn't have been so happy to see someone so dangerous, but if they were going to team with villains, better they at least pull their own weight.

"Agent Quantum," the dragon greeted. "You should follow me. There's quite a few people on your heels, and this isn't the place to deal with them."



Lozora didn't especially care about how they'd done it. All that mattered was that the New Science Sentries had gotten inside. Really, she'd done everything but leave a neon sign and a key in the lock, but they'd managed it eventually. With them in position, the preamble could finally come to an end. It was time to get down to business.

On her phone, she sent a single message: "The piñata is stuffed." With that, her employer was officially notified. Nearby, blocking devices keyed to specific signals engaged, triggered by her message. In other parts of the city, different teams were turned loose, creating a buffer of crime in case any passing patrol might head their way. The capes wouldn't be able to call for any more backup. From this point on, they were stuck with what they had until the man who'd put it all together arrived. She still wasn't sure how he would make the approach—perhaps by air, or maybe burrowing up from under the street. It wouldn't really even shock her if he simply walked out of a coffee shop and strolled up to the front door. The man loved to keep secrets, even from those in his employ, and that included his own entry methods. It didn't especially matter; Lozora had kept her end of the bargain and brought the target into the trap. If her employer failed from this point on, there was no one to blame but himself.

Nevertheless, she still rose and prepared to take a more active role if needed. Whether the blame would be deserved or not, she'd dealt with enough despots to know they rarely saw fault within themselves. Making sure this stayed on the rails was how she ensured there were no snafus in her payday.

Besides, after working so hard to put this piece on the board, there was no way Lozora was going to miss the actual game.

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## Chapter 110

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It was kind of like watching the inception of a parade. As Agent Quantum ran, the rest of the crowd came alive, realizing something of note was happening. If there'd been any doubt in Hephaestus's mind who they were here for, it vanished at the obvious reactions from the hodgepodge army. This was their target all right, and they pursued him with the gusto one would expect after so much milling around. Together, they surged forward on his heels, slowed by their own numbers but giving chase nonetheless, forming a river of bodies in Agent Quantum's wake.

The gauntlets were primed and ready, and from the glow rippling off Plasmodia, she was in a similar state. Cyber Geek sat posted up on the actual edge of the roof, hidden by a cloak he'd pulled out as he kept an eye on the goings on through the scope on his huge *Blaster Brahs* gun. Only Presto didn't look ready to fire, since he had an entirely different job to do.

"Once Agent Quantum and Tachyonic are clear, aim for the middle of the crowd. Let's break them up and limit how many get inside." Cyber Geek gave the orders, since obviously the villains weren't being trusted to *that* extent, though Hephaestus had no objection to the situation. Between the two of them, Cyber Geek had logged far more hours in actual combat with just this last year, to say nothing of Donald's love for games that required tactics and strategy. And it meant she was free to break off if need be without leaving them in the lurch. "Remember, stunning shots only."

That last bit was obviously directed at Hephaestus, who rolled her eyes even though no one else could see through the helmet. "I bet that's what all their weapons are set at, too."



“Doesn’t matter,” Cyber Geek rebutted. “We aren’t them. We’re superheroes. No more bloodshed than is absolutely necessary.”

There was the end of their discussion, as Agent Quantum finally made it through the front door, a blur on his heels less than a second later. No one needed the cue—they’d all just gotten it—and almost in unison, the shots burst forth.

Hephaestus’s gauntlet beams didn’t really have a “stun” setting, so instead, she fired a few feet in front of the crowd, creating visible damage in the concrete and pulling most of them up short. Some kept right on going, only to be smacked aside by bright bolts blasting out of Plasmodia’s hands. Based on how hard they were being sent flying from those shots, Hephaestus had a hunch they were only just barely on the non-lethal side, perhaps the weakest Plasmodia could manage.

For the bulk of the group that stopped at the sight of Hephaestus’s beams, Cyber Geek had something special. He fired directly into the center of them, releasing an explosion of crackling blue light that sent nearly every crook hit down to the ground, twitching. They couldn’t have asked for a better opening shot, which was a good thing, because with eyes twisting upward, their advantage of surprise was officially spent.

No more freebies. Now, they were getting fired back on. Chunks of brick exploded into the air as they all ducked down, save for the lone member who hadn’t fired a single shot yet. Smacking his hands on his costume’s pants, Presto tilted his head up to the sky. “Looks like that’s my cue.”

He vanished, reappearing some distance off, much higher up. That position lasted only a moment before he was gone again. Hephaestus carefully approached the roof’s edge as the shots tapered off, poking her helmet up while making sure to stay in flame form inside, just to be safe. What greeted her was a scene of masterful chaos.

Presto was there, popping around, moving the crooks along with him. Whenever he saw one taking aim to shoot, they’d suddenly find themselves reoriented, firing into a fellow criminal. Not only were they taking one another out, but the ersatz betrayals were causing fights among their ranks. He darted around like that for nearly a full minute before vanishing, only to reappear overhead, then pop directly to their sides once more.

“That should give you all a little breathing room. We can do this trick maybe twice more before they wise up and really focus fire on the roof.

Also, heads up to the indoor team, I saw a few slipping in the front during the confusion.” While he kept the panting out of his voice, Presto’s chest was rising and falling quickly—using so much power had left him winded.

“Good. It means we’re doing our job right,” Plasmodia said. “Break them up into manageable chunks for the rest to handle.”

Hephaestus tilted a head to the well-manicured hands that were rippling with energy. “I think you could break them into literal chunks. Those sure seem easier to handle.”

“I told you, we’re not doing that,” Cyber Geek snapped.

“You say that now, while things are going well. What if the tide starts to turn? What are you willing to do when your team’s lives are at risk?”

She’d expected another canned reply, but that was her own failing. This was not just a generic cape, no matter how often he could fall into the habits of one. Donald Moss was a man who loved superheroes, yes, but who also thought deeply about the things he did. “I know that sometimes, there is no getting around a lethal shot in this job. I had to kill an interdimensional monster on my first time out, but that same situation could have easily happened with a meta-human. Even Lodestar has had to throw that final punch a few times. Whether or not it’s in me to kill another person, I don’t think I’ll know until the moment comes, but I refuse to take that step a single moment before it becomes absolutely necessary.”

“Agent Quantum would make the same call.” It was perhaps the first time Hephaestus had noticed Plasmodia really look at Cyber Geek since arriving on the roof.

Even Presto seemed a tad impressed, if one paid more attention to his tone than his words. “Yeesh, now we’ve got another of them to compensate for.”

There was clearly no winning this battle, so Hephaestus opted to let it go, though she couldn’t resist one final bit of parting wisdom. “I admire your resolution and dedication to your ideals. Just remember, there’s a cost to taking the high road.”

Cyber Geek’s eyebrows pinched as he pointedly looked up and down the armored suit. “As opposed to your way?”

“Oh no, my road has its own costs, too. I imagine they all do.”

Hephaestus returned to the roofline, gauntlets charged to fire once more. “But I live my life prepared to pay them. Be sure you’re ready to do the same.”



This was, in Medley's estimation, total bullshit. Being behind Agent Quantum's combat skills had been one thing. He was the inheritor of a legacy team, and had clearly been provided with ample training as part of that. The fact that Medley could fight on nearly the same level was almost a point of pride, even if Agent Quantum was clearly ahead. But now, before his eyes, Medley was realizing that he wasn't the second strongest member of this motley combat team: he was third.

As it turned out, Bahamut was quite a great deal more adept at brawling than Hephaestus. While the former used his suit's bulk and weapons to make up for gaps in skill, Bahamut had no such failings to cover. Despite the size, he was quick and sure, cracking the man emitting smoke from his ears hard in the ribs, sending him tumbling to the ground. A huge fellow with some kind of cobbled-together electro-axe swung for Bahamut's flank while he should have been distracted, except the green dragon ducked under the blow, striking back with a kick to the knees that earned a horrific yowl from the axe-wielder as he crumpled to the ground.

It was to Medley's disadvantage that he was on the side of the capes in this contest. Unlike Bahamut, he and Agent Quantum were putting their targets down with as little damage as they could manage, while the dragon seemed to be paying a passing effort at most to not being lethal. Near Agent Quantum, a goon produced dripping purple blades from his arms, angling them directly for the cape. He never even came close, as Bahamut grabbed him from behind, spun the man's arms, and sank both blades into the limbs of two other crooks, both of whom dropped to the ground immediately.

"Oh, that stuff is dangerous," Bahamut noted. He twisted the arms inward, the captive struggling vainly against the dragon's superior might, until the blades were plunged into the wielder's own legs. While it did appear to hurt, he didn't have the same reaction as the first pair.

"Stupid fucking lizard, of course I'm immune to my own poison."

"Guess that does make sense." The *crack* turned Medley's stomach, even before he looked to confirm. Sure enough, Bahamut had snapped poison-blade's arms at the elbow; both were hanging limply at his sides.

"Looks like you're not immune to broken bones, though. Or concussions."

That was the only warning before Bahamut's fist smashed into his face, sending the broken man flying back into a wall, where he wouldn't be able

to sneak up on them with those potent blades. Agent Quantum looked aghast, but in the midst of a fray, he didn't exactly have the spare time to object.

As for Medley, he deflected a pair of bone-daggers hurled by one of his nearest opponents, then noticed they were still airborne, floating around to his rear. Somebody was pairing with a telekinetic; a smart combination, but less useful once noticed. Medley dropped to a crouch, his body's natural pouncing position, then leapt, jumping over the bone thrower to an inconspicuous invader who'd been hanging to the sides. A surprised face, one swift punch, and just like that, the daggers clattered down once more. The physical threats were straightforward to deal with; they had to handle anyone who could throw curves as soon as possible.

So far, things had been going well. In fact, they'd gone so well that Medley didn't trust it. In the months since he'd been changed and joined the Alliance of Heroic Champions, there had been a great many lessons to learn; one of the earliest was that battles never went to plan. Out in the field, things were chaotic, messy, unpredictable. Plans were meant to be shapes of things, general guides to trust and use as a compass. Details always shifted on the fly. Yet somehow, while totally surrounded and trapped, it was all working flawlessly. The outer team was slowing the slew of entrants enough to where just three of their fighters could handle it, and apparently, none of the crooks considered the idea of taking another route inside.

No, something was definitely off. The only way things went this well if it was a piece of *both* parties' plans. Except, Medley couldn't see what gain there was to this setup. How did letting them whittle away at the troops help whoever had put this all together? Were the bodies booby-trapped, or rigged to suddenly regain consciousness and heal? They smelled normal enough, so far as he could tell, but with metas, there was never truly a way to be sure.

Unfortunately, Medley's only current available tactic was the "wait and see" move. Once he knew what the point of all this was, he could start working more directly against whoever was pulling the strings. Until then, he had to play the game long enough to reach the end, which meant keeping up with Agent Quantum and Bahamut as they took down new threats.

Tachyonic appeared in the room, zipping in from another hallway. "You've got a team on the way. I took out two of them, but three more are

still coming. A new group just entered—I'll lead them around a bit until you're clear." As quickly as he'd arrived, the speedster was gone, back to running in-building interference.

That, like everything else, was working well. Medley had a hunch that things would continue to keep going their way, until the trend very abruptly stopped. Sooner or later, the synchronized plans would diverge, and these criminals' real goal would come into focus. When that moment arrived was when the deadliest part of the fight began.



The Wrexwren ship was flying over a long stretch of ocean, searching for a viable landing target, when a message hit their comms system. It was from another Wrexwren vessel, reporting that they'd discovered an excellent find not far away. Little defense, ample resources, even natural features that would make a sustained occupation more viable; they were calling for reinforcements to help raid and hold their discovery. Redirecting course, the pilot angled for the other ship's beacon, homing in and locking the location.

In a matter of minutes, they'd shot across the sky, arriving at what appeared to be a huge chunk of land surrounded by ocean—an island, as the humans called them. This island had a great many human-built structures, the most striking of which was a massive castle that gleamed wherever light struck, metal coating most, if not all, of its surface. The Wrexwren pilot looked to the rest of his crew; this was certainly not what the transmission had promised. Something was amiss, and with no backup anywhere nearby, the prudent call was to evacuate.

As he tried to steer them away from the island, however, it became clear that the ship was no longer in control of its own movements. Below, they could see energy lashes dig into the sides of their vessel, pulling it roughly down from the sky, onto a metal pad waiting below. They prepared themselves for combat, readying weapons to make a final stand and show these humans the might of the Wrexwren fighting spirit.

Sadly, such a fight was never to occur. When the ship got with fifteen feet of the circle below, a pulse shot up, delivering a tremendous dose of electrical current to everything inside it. Some of the Wrexwren initially survived, but they had no time to recover before the ship was pulled all the

way down and the roof roughly opened. Mechanical limbs reached in, yanking out the pilot's crew as he struggled vainly to reach for them, arms barely even capable of a twitch.

"Looks like we've got one that can still move. Put him in the observation tank. The rest are dead or dying—get them directly to our dissection room. Our leader wants these as fresh as possible."

Above the Wrexwren, a human face appeared, looking at him with none of the typical sentiment they'd been told to expect from this species. The human examined him once, then moved its skull in a side-to-side motion. "Really, if you're falling for tricks this simple, someone really must have fed you a lot of misinformation about Earth. Did they paint us a simple rubes in the backwater of the galaxy, huddling together out of fear of the unknown? Our planet is much like this place, the island built by Tyranny. Lovely to gaze at, yet so much more deadly than appearances would ever let on."

The human made a noise, a light series of expulsions from its mouth—perhaps this was their version of laughter. "I'm sure that sounds ridiculous to a mighty invader like yourself, but in time, I think you'll understand. You see, the ones currently being dragged away were fortunate. For them, this nightmare is already done. Fate was not nearly so kind to you." He leaned back, motioning to someone unseen. "All right, get him moving. We need to reset the trap for the next batch."

Metal reached into the cab, tearing the Wrexwren pilot out of his seat, dragging him into the damp Earth air as his screeching whistles echoed through the night.

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## Chapter 111

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Where in the hell was he? All this work, weeks of scheming, planning, luring in an entire alien invasion to serve as a distraction, and now, when the goal was at hand, her employer was late? That didn't track. No way would he miss this. Catching the New Science Sentries had been all he focused on, the lone goal driving every action. Something was up, and Lozora didn't like it, especially when she'd yet to be paid.

Finishing her coffee, she dropped a few bills on the table and rose, striding out to the street all other civilians were steering clear of. Shots rained down from the apartment building's rooftop, receiving return fire that tore at the brick exterior of the building. Real guns would have little to no impact, which was why her crew was outfitted with more effective options. Given enough time, they could clear out the whole wall running along the roofline. Hence why the capes shooting back were being certain not to give the gang that kind of opportunity.

Lozora moved easily through the road, steering clear of the brawl like any normal person would. She slipped up a few streets, circling around and coming at the building from the other side. A few others could be spotted using the same tactic, though for the most part, everyone was sticking at the front. Well, they hadn't been hired for their on-the-job thinking skills. Mostly, they were just intended to be fodder, though for what purpose still remained a mystery to her. Unlike the others, she went unnoticed until reaching the building itself. Using her strength, it was a small matter to scurry up the exterior to a second-story window, then smash her way inside.

She'd chosen a dark apartment, and it appeared to be currently unoccupied, which was perfect. Lozora wasn't necessarily going to join the battle—that wasn't what she'd been contracted for—but she had no intention of letting her employer get everything he wanted and then skip out on the bill. For as little as she knew about his plans as a whole, one way or another, it would end with the New Science Sentries. So long as she stayed near them, her employer would turn up.

Until then, it was a matter of laying low. When he inevitably arrived, there was truly no telling what might happen, save only that the New Science Sentries were unlikely to survive it.



Finally.

Doctor Mechanical reran the simulation again and again, testing external variables for differing results, yet none of it seemed to matter. So long as the meltdown process was started properly, minor details like position and active velocity had no impact whatsoever. They'd found their move, but there were still a few more details to handle. It wouldn't do to give away the turn too early.

The first preparation step was to take control of the ship's communications. Blocking the signals from Earth had been a minor chore to set up before they left; this was quite a bit more comprehensive. From the Wrexwren version of cameras currently trained on Lodestar, to the actual signals being relayed between ships, Doctor Mechanical took control of every last scrap. As of this moment, the Wrexwren on the main vessel would see and hear only what he permitted.

With that done, he scanned the general chatter as Xelas dummied up a few programs to simulate the same amount of mid-battle noise. It wouldn't fool anyone truly perceptive, and even the slower ones would catch on eventually, but it wasn't as if this charade needed to stand the test of time. It didn't particularly matter if they saw through it, really; the damage would be done, except this would give Fornax a more powerful tool to use when the time was right.

Control established, preparations in place, and the right sequence discovered. There was no need for he or Xelas to move their physical heads,



not when they were already working together so closely in digital space. They did pause for a moment to confer, making completely sure that both were ready to proceed. Once they made the call, there was no turning back on multiple fronts.

Together, unseen by any of the Wrexwren who were still laughing as they watched Zerle Salvrin smack around Fornax, Doctor Mechanial and Xelas activated their creation.

It was, at its heart, only a signal. A signal carrying specific programming, one designed to bypass the Wrexwren security completely and cause a series of sequential activations within the engines. Just a signal, yet with it, the Wrexwren invasion functionally came to an end, even if it would take the aliens some time to fully understand the loss they'd incurred. Most would die with no idea of what had even happened—a small blessing that proved Doctor Mechanial wasn't entirely heartless.

Since there was no more need to play nice, he and Xelas both raised their weapons, unnoticed by the Wrexwren who'd written them both off entirely. A few bright flashes and some whistle-screams, then they were alone, that annoying rabble of laughter muted at long last. It felt good, but not nearly so fine as the sensation of broadcasting a message to his friend's ears, letting him know the first part of the fight was over. No more sandbagging.

"Fornax, this is Doctor Mechanial. Injury has been accomplished. You are free to proceed with adding Insult."



Despite the distance, she saw them go. Lodestar was burning bright with power, operating at what most of the world thought to be her maximum. They were close on that front, as this was what she considered to be her terrestrial maximum—things got dangerous if she swung much more power than this around while planet-side. But the truth was, so far as she knew, a Lodestar had no true limit. There was always more power to be drawn. The only question was how much of the person would remain afterward.

Using her power was like stealing some primal force of the universe to make herself bigger, in a metaphysical sense rather than a literal one. The more she drew, the greater her capabilities, but the less of *her* there was in

comparison. As the power flowed in, it became harder and harder to stay Helen. That was how Lodestars changed, based on the multiverse research they'd managed. One drew in more than they could find their way back from.

There was a time even brushing against her current level might have caused some concern, but that was very long ago indeed. She was, to her knowledge, one of the longer-lived incarnations of Lodestar, and had a very strong hunch as to why. Most Lodestars were cut off, their tremendous power and responsibility making it near impossible for them to feel truly connected with anyone else. Who could possibly relate to that kind of burden? But she was different. Friends, family, the simple thought of her daughter, all of it bonded her to that world, to the life she lived outside this costume.

She was Helen, who served as the Lodestar, while knowing *exactly* who she was. And right at that moment, she was furious. With Ivan and the guild, for what they'd just done. With the Wrexwren, for putting them in that position to begin with. With herself, more than anything. Maybe there was a way it didn't have to be like this. A world where, if she'd been stronger, faster, or smarter, there would be less bloodshed. It was a very familiar anger, one that had burned in her since the first day she woke with these powers, and *without* her parents or brother.

Earth-maximum was clearly not going to cut it. Still, she had to press on incrementally. Trying to kill this creature outright because of her own fury would make her just as bad as the guild. But those increments were about to start increasing sharply, by necessity if not intent.

Truth be told, when she started using this kind of power, not even Lodestar could completely control it. For the Scralthor's sake, she really hoped it was smart enough to run while it still had a chance.



Doctor Mechaniacal's voice in his ear was both welcome and terrifying. Welcome, because even Ivan was starting to get weary of taking blow after blow constantly. Terrifying, because compared to what came next, that was the equivalent of sitting on a park bench on a sunny afternoon. He was

going to have to do something genuinely horrifying, and there was simply no way around it.

With so many meta-humans and people watching at home, no subterfuge would go undiscovered, no trickery could slip the collective consciousness. The plan called for Fornax, which was why he'd donned the mask and name once more. Except, the reputation wasn't enough. For this to work, for the message to get through, he couldn't be Ivan playing pretend. Everything had to be real, so there were no loose threads to unravel.

Pretending wasn't enough. Today, he had to *be* Fornax once more. And that was what made Ivan so scared, as the darkness filled his eyes and runes appeared in their place: how incredibly easy it was for that first mad giggle to come bounding past his lips, like it had been waiting just below the surface for a chance to rise.

It was a strange time to laugh, given that he was currently leaning against the wall, having been sent there by Zerle Salvrin's mighty fists. The Wrexwren was struck by the sound, turning its head in some manner—though without eyes, it was hard to view any section as the “front” with certainty.

“Zerle Salvrin, I came here expecting to be disappointed, but you... you *are* worthy.” Fornax rose, not bothered by the blood dripping from parts of his face. That was what the mask was for, and anyway, it wasn't as if he hadn't fought through far worse pain than this.

“I need be worthy to kill one so pitiful as you?” He seemed insulted by the idea, charging right up with a fresh attack. Only, this one didn't land like all the others. Despite the twisting madness of his movement, Zerle Salvrin found one arm caught by Fornax, while the red-masked man dodged the other strikes. There was brief moment as they looked upon one another, before Fornax's fist sent Zerle Salvrin flying back to the other side of the chamber.

“You are worthy of being broken.” Fornax was smiling now, genuine glee as he took in the rasped, unsteady nature of the Wrexwren's whistles. He might have hit whatever their version of lungs was. “Only the strong can truly be destroyed, you see. The weak have too much bend. They lack suitable pride to be humbled, confidence to shatter. Even the things they love, they understand might be stolen away by fate or another. Not like the

strong, who believe we can push against the very will of the universe when what's ours is threatened."

Zerle Salvrin didn't simply lay on the ground and suffer abuse. He was up in short order, but approached with far greater caution this time. The movements were closer to his initial attacks, before he'd felt certain in his victory: guarded, probing, a much more defensive tactic now that he knew his opponent was capable of hitting back. Fornax allowed three blows to land on various points of his body, and in return, he slammed a fist into the same spot he'd hit the first time, sending Zerle Salvrin flying again with a fresh round of rasping.

"You think you can kill me that easily?" Zerle Salvrin was already rising again. It looked as if he could take as hard as he gave—no wonder this being had attained such a high position among his species.

"Kill you? My good Zerle, you truly have zero grasp on what is happening. If someone wanted you killed, there is no shortage of options available to us. We could have obliterated you from the ground weeks ago. You are not so fortunate as to get an executioner. I am Fornax, and my one true gift is destruction. Death is easy. Instead, I am going to break every piece of who you are. Then, if you ask very nicely, I may just grant you an ending."

The whistle had a very snarl-like quality as it rang out, which matched the aggressive posture Zerle Salvrin was adopting, visibly prepared for another bout. "Empty threats. Even if you are stronger than I, my people have well prepared me for torture. I've endured it on missions more than once. There is no breaking of Zerle Salvrin."

Fornax's smile grew substantially wider. "Excellent. That's right, tell me how pointless it is. Tell me how you will absolutely, unquestionably triumph. Show me your strength, Zerle Salvrin. Show my world your power, so that your shattering will be all the greater."

This time, Fornax didn't counter the attacks. He merely dodged them, stepping nimbly out of the way so the myriad of Wrexwren limbs struck only air. "But you know, I really can't stand fighting in all this silence. Down on Earth, things are messy and chaotic. By now, we'd have people screaming and yelling, possibly even a few interlopers to deal with. Doctor Mechaniacal, would you be so kind as to give us a soundtrack?"

This time, the voice didn't reply over the communicator. Doctor Mechaniacal's reply echoed through the entire chamber, broadcast along

whatever system was still showing Lodestar squaring off with the Scralthor overhead. “My pleasure, Fornax. In fact, I have just the thing.”

The closest sound Fornax could compare to what came next was a truckload of whistles crashing in a hurricane, which then blew through each one. A cacophony of crunching, crashing, shrill noises, most of which were all nonsense. Only a few soundbites were clear enough for his translator to make them out.

“They’re everywhere. We can’t get out!”

“—large teeth and glowing red eyes, killed—”

“—entire crew eviscerated—”

“—a trap!”

“Seems like this was planned—”

“Zerle, this is a world woven of death.”

That last one was rather poetic, assuming it was the Wrexwren’s actual words and not the translator’s approximation. Zerle Salvrin, however, was not reacting nearly so well to these new sounds. Given that he understood all of them, it was probably quite the bloody accounting of how their invasion was going so far. Selectively blocking the signals had been vital, both to keep the Wrexwren cocky and to ensure Zerle Salvrin was properly caught off guard. Now, he was learning the truth of how his people were faring, or at least, the relative few that might still be alive.

“If you want to break someone at their core, you must first understand what makes up their foundation. From where do they draw their strength. As you informed Lodestar, you are a Zerle, an earned rank, no doubt connected to your position on this ship. I do wonder, how many are required under your command to be a Zerle? Is there a specific number needed? How about you count the ones we hear actually die, and you tell me when I need to start addressing you by another title.”

This noise was nearly a train whistle, a furious burst from Zerle Salvrin which served as the only warning before he sprang, a wild mass of limbs moving faster than any blow thrown before. As planned, he was now fighting for real. No more putting on a show or taking his time; Zerle Salvrin was swinging for the kill. That too was an important part of the process: he had to bring his very best to the fight.

Because that would make Fornax crushing him all the more painful.

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## Chapter 112

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Between the trickle of goons making it through only to be smacked down, the shots on the roof doing some damage on their own, and the few smart enough to leave after they noticed that dozens had gone into the building without anyone reemerging, they were making a surprisingly good pace through the siege's attackers. A worryingly good pace, if Tachyonic was being honest. For as relatively new to the field as he was, it wasn't as if Vomisa were without any dangers of its own. Tachyonic had been in enough tight spots to trust his instincts, all of which were screaming that something was off. Whoever had thrown this together put in a lot of effort. There was virtually no chance it would be settled so easily.

That's why Tachyonic was doing a thorough sweep while he had the opportunity, making sure that none of the crooks were secretly planting explosives or setting up meta-tech devices while everyone else was distracted. Thus far, he'd come up entirely empty. The only things he was passing as he ran were the toppled bodies of criminals that had already been taken out. They were scattered through the halls, most in various states of unconsciousness, with a few showing more substantial injuries—largely the ones who'd been unlucky enough to fight Bahamut.

He paused near an electrical panel that was slightly askew, stepping over three knocked-out minions to get at it. Maybe they'd been doing something when they were interrupted, and the others hadn't noticed? Yanking open the door, he scanned over the interior, finding nothing amiss. While he wouldn't have been capable of puzzling out the workings of some

complex device, he trusted himself to at least tell if the wires had been yanked out and messed with.

Unfortunately, all that focus on the panel took away from other potential threats, though it wasn't as if he'd have paid much attention to a defeated foe in the first place. That's what made it such a perfect hiding space.

The pain was instant, swift, and terrifying: a burning spike driven directly through his left ankle, forcing Tachyonic to lean against the wall as his leg suddenly refused to bear weight. Spinning around, he saw one of the bodies calmly rising to its feet. It appeared to be a largely unremarkable man—plain clothes and simple looks, not even any meta-tech on hand. On the subject on hands, Tachyonic noticed that this fellow did have one very distinguishing feature: his left hand was gaunt, almost skeletal, with dark wisps of smoke rising off it. The smoke was quite similar to a small tendril drifting out of Tachyonic's new ankle-hole, making the puzzle of what had happened a simple solve.

Struggling, Tachyonic tried to move, hopping slightly away. To his shock, the man made no immediate lunge, but rather followed slowly, as if he had no reason in the world to hurry. Did he not realize that with enough time, Tachyonic could call for backup?

No. He wanted the call for backup to go out. Suddenly, it all made much more sense. Whoever this was had been lying in wait, next to a trap that would draw in any superhero doing a perimeter sweep. He'd hobbled their fastest member in a single blow—that was not a coincidence. Having the power to do such a thing meant nothing if one couldn't create opportunity. This was someone with a plan, and there was little hope that playing into it worked out well for the New Science Sentries.

The trouble was, if he radioed and warned everyone, there was a strong possibility they might come anyway. Were he to know a friend was in danger, Agent Quantum wouldn't turn back, and the others would be hot on his heels. Their best shot was if Tachyonic could escape and warn them in person. It might still come down to a fight; the goal was just not to have it on this mystery attacker's terms.

Running on an ankle with a hole in the middle would be painful as hell, but the real problem was how much it would slow him down. Still, he'd be limping at super-speeds, so hopefully that beat out the ambusher's running pace. Tilting forward, Tachyonic took off, bolting himself forward. Except something was wrong, more than just his foot. His speed was diluted,

weakened, even with the bracer confirming that he was indeed getting a constant setlium output.

He'd barely gotten ten steps down the hall when a strong hand fell upon his shoulder, jerking him back effortlessly. Tachyonic flew into drywall as he was tossed, leaving a sizable dent and receiving a good rattle to the skull. By the time he looked up, the attacker was standing above him once more, staring down with a smile that didn't fit the skin of his face.

"One of life's cruel humors; I am the opposing element to your power source. That potent setlium crackling in your cells is suddenly not working so well now that my energy is in the mix, corrupting the bonds that fuel your abilities. The good news is that the effects will fade, eventually. Assuming you survive."

It was not his smoking left hand, but his still human-looking right that reached forward. Although Tachyonic tried to struggle from the ground, it was useless. This man wasn't just strong in the sense of Agent Quantum: he was on a whole other level, closer to Professor Quantum. Nothing Tachyonic did, from pulling at his arms to a full-force punch in the face, made any impact. The superhero might as well have been a stiff breeze. The attacks were short-lived, as he soon found his head pressed against the wall as the stranger waved a device next to his ear. When his attacker spoke again, Tachyonic realized with horror that he didn't just hear it nearby, it was coming through the communicators, as well.

"Good morning, New Science Sentries. I'm pleased at how well you've done with the warm-up exercises, but the time has come to take things to the next level. We now know you to be capable of the basics for superhero work. Let us next test your bravery. I have taken Tachyonic, and he won't be escaping without help. Playing with him will likely keep me occupied for some while, long enough that the rest of you might get away. Time for your first choice, New Science Sentries. Come save your friend, or live to fight another day. You have five minutes to find us. After that, I'll put a new hole in him for every minute the entire team isn't present. Oh, and as you can tell, I'm tapped into your lines. If anyone decides to try to reach the AHC, I'll leave Tachyonic's body in the lobby. His head... now that you'll have to search for."

Fighting through the pain, Tachyonic stared into those cold, distant eyes. "Why are you doing this? We don't know you. There's no grudge here."



“Poor little pawn. He’s so cruel as to send you out into the world with no idea what you’ll truly be facing, yet somehow, I’m the monster?” While the words might have crafted a veneer of sympathy, there was no touch of humanity in those words. “Take heart, because this isn’t really about you. It never could have been—not if you’d spent decades building to the New Science Sentries’ legacy. He would have never let it be that way. You were always destined to die a footnote, just one more person for Professor Quantum to step over in his quest for greatness.”

It might not be the nicest sentiment, but at least it made sense. The New Science Sentries hadn’t gotten into nearly enough trouble to have grudges like this held against them. The Science Sentries in their original incarnation, especially with Professor Quantum in the lead, would be a very different story. And as someone who’d grown up around Professor Quantum, Tachyonic had no trouble believing someone could hate the man that much. In other circumstances, it might even have been a point of bonding.

“Look, I’m sorry if Professor Quantum screwed you over in some way. That’s just who he is. You’re one of countless. But it has nothing to do with us.”

“So very wrong, on multiple levels,” the attacker countered. “You became part of it when he gave you that name, when he decided to add to his legacy using you four as tools. You are connected to his accomplishments—which is to say, his ego—and nothing hurts him more than being attacked there. Besides which, I am not ‘one of countless’ as you implied. I am, without question, the first one destroyed by Professor Quantum’s ambition.”

“What makes you so sure of that?” Tachyonic spat, half hoping to keep him distracted, half trying to keep his mind off the pain in his ankle.

There was a placidness to the man as he spread his arms, one hand normal, the other letting off plumes of dark smoke. “Because on the day he betrayed me, his name was still Vernon.”



Sunshine covered the green landscape, where verdant trees and lush grass grew in every direction. As the Wrexwren moved, it noted the structure up

ahead: simple, yet large and well-maintained. This was a lived-in area, which made it more dangerous. The rest of the team would be circling, ensuring they took the occupants by surprise.

In front of the structure, many tiny humans were running about, wasting their already short lives on frivolity. Such energy would be better used in industries across the galaxy, once the Wrexwren understood how much labor a human body could endure at various levels of growth. There would be trial and error, but there was no shortage of subjects to learn from.

Stepping out of the woods, the Wrexwren leader began to raise his weapon, only to have his view cut off. The rest of his team was around him—only, chunks of their bodies had been torn out. Worse, there were more appearing: the Stropolof warriors they'd mowed through, the devoted innocents who'd been wiped out by his fire on Tregle-9. More and more, the past appeared, all of it looking right at him, deadly hatred in their eyes.

Together, the mass of unseen horrors descended upon the Wrexwren leader, viciously tearing him apart as they had the rest of his crew. None of the playing children witnessed any of this, however. They were busy making a fort with their current caretaker, a grown man with dirty-blond hair. He alone looked to the dying Wrexwren, no pity whatsoever present on that serene face. For a moment, in the pain of death, the alien believed he saw something else, like a pair of metal wings extending behind the peaceful man.

Kristoph handed out fresh crayons to a child drawing the landscape, not a single Wrexwren or ship to be seen in the artwork. Taking a role of protection had made the most sense for him on this chaotic day. While the Wrexwren invasion would no doubt have casualties among every age group, there was little purpose to hunting them down.

The guild was already making sure that when the day was done, the Wrexwren would thoroughly answer for their crimes.



“Holy shit.” Presto stopped cold, and Plasmodia looked as though she might be ill. The smaller cape’s face was hidden by his mask, yet the anger made it into his words without any obstruction whatsoever. “Oh, this guy is so dead.”

“He could be bluffing.” Plasmodia’s rebuttal was weak—she didn’t believe it. This was a moment’s respite in brief denial.

“Not on our communication channel, he isn’t.” Presto started for the roofline, only to be snared by Cyber Geek.

Hephaestus, for her part, was mostly trying to keep the blasts raining down, though the available targets were getting thin. After a prolonged period of firing and letting them past in batches, most were either inside, injured, or had decided this was not worth the effort and bailed. “Anyone want to loop me in on what’s going on? Temporary allies and all?”

She was unprepared for the furious dervish who suddenly appeared next to her, Presto grabbing her helmet and trying to force it into his eye-line. “You! If you had anything to do with—”

Hephaestus jerked her helmet forward. She nearly smashed Presto in the nose until he leapt away at the last moment, though she did succeed in her attempt at breaking his grip. “I have about had it with the goddamn threats. In case you didn’t notice, I am not a fucking cape, and I do *not* have to be here putting up with your shit. Flying out has been an option from the start. Now, will you cut the posturing and tell me if there’s anything new I need to know about?”

“Someone captured Tachyonic and sent a message over the nearby AHC communicators.” The response came not from Presto, who was still fuming, but rather from Cyber Geek. “They’re going to torture him until the New Science Sentries come help. And apparently kill him if we attempt to call in any backup.”

Suddenly, Presto’s rage made a great deal more sense. What she comprehended less, however, was the unforeseen surge of anger that suddenly tore up from Tori’s gut. There was a time when she wouldn’t have understood what it meant, but Lodestar’s words still hung heavy on her mind. She could put up all the walls, pretend that there weren’t bonds, and go through her entire life acting as if she had no human connections. Lying to herself was the only area where it was doomed to fail. Because deep down, she knew when she felt that instinctive reaction, that every part of her was saying *No*. Tachyonic... Kyle... was intrusive, often said the wrong thing, and had generally made her life more complicated since he’d arrived in it.

But he was her friend. She could accept that now, while there was still time to act, or later, when nothing she did would matter.

Just like that, the world made sense again. It didn't matter if he was a cape, or a villain, a meta-human, an alien, a god, or a demon. She wanted him around, alive, and that made him *hers*, in a sense. If there was one thing that defined Tori Rivas, one truth carved into her soul as she endured the beeping hell of watching her parents slowly fade away, it was this:

*No one* stole from her. No one took what was hers, be it items, ideas, or people she cared for. Whoever this person was, they had made a huge mistake. It wasn't merely the capes they'd pissed off with that move, they'd caught the attention of a dangerous villain, as well.

"Then why the hell are you all still standing here? Shouldn't we be sweeping for him?"

The three capes looked at her, visible worry in their eyes. Hephaestus been an ally so far, but also an adversary in the past. With the stakes suddenly dire, their tenuous trust was stretched thin, torn between the need for more bodies in the fight versus pairing with people they actually trusted.

"I feel like one of you is about to threaten me yet again, which is not only unneeded, at this point, it's actively rude. You don't like me, fine. Don't trust me, that's fair too. But you're all smart enough to understand that I'm a guild member, meaning that there are rules I play by. Torturing and killing capes is not a part of that. Whoever this person is, they're disrespecting my organization, as well. Now, that's not the same as 'kidnapped friend' for motivation, sure, but it's more than enough reason to plant my beam in the base of their skull."

"Let Hephaestus come. What matters most is getting Tachyonic back. Anything else, we can deal with after." Presto headed toward the rooftop doorway, his only way into the building since they lacked a clear line of sight. "But we stay together as we move. Anyone capable of taking down Tachyonic is not to be underestimated."

The mere fact that Presto, of all people, was being so serious drove the gravity of the situation home. Hephaestus followed the capes from the roof, leaving the few straggling goons waiting for shots that would never come. They had a new threat to deal with, and this one was not nearly so easily countered.

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## Chapter 113

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“The new guy is kind of intense.” Pest Control directed his swarm of meta-hornets into the Wrexwren cockpit, drawing more whistle-screams from within. Whatever physical characteristics the aliens had, immunity to insects that had been mutated by a chemical spill was not among them. Since adding these specimens to his arsenal, the villain’s deadliness had gone up considerably, though this was his first chance to really cut loose with them.

Nearby, Glyph snapped in triumph as a different Wrexwren soldier stepped into one of the hidden magical runes placed along the ground. Without warning, he turned on his comrade, firing onto the other Wrexwren who’d trusted their leader with their lives, killing several before they managed to shoot back and bring it all to an end. “Yeah, he’s really racking up the bodies.”

From the trees, the humanoid form dropped, sinking claws into a Wrexwren’s neck before savagely digging further, sending sprays of alien liquid all along the lush grass. He leapt off the still-standing corpse, laying his fangs into another Wrexwren while pointing its own weapon toward more invaders. As pain took over, the alien tensed, sending errant shots sizzling through the air.

“Emory hasn’t had much chance to test himself in the field yet—he’s got to rebuild his sense of power and self, especially after the training he went through.” Arcanicus reinforced the magical shield around them, a form of power which the Wrexwren were showing no capacity for

whatsoever. If they hadn't even been prepared for mystical forces, they were woefully unready to try to take on Earth.

"We all had training," Pest Control pointed out.

"You had a group experience. Emory has been entirely in the hands of his mentor to mold." Arcanicus had to look momentarily away as their newest guild apprentice ripped the scaly exterior from a Wrexwren's body, drawing horrific noises in the process. He usually didn't mind watching over the newer members—they weren't ambitious or competent enough to cause much trouble yet—but this bout was making him wish he'd prepared a stomach-soothing potion.

Glyph appeared to have a similar reaction, shaking his head at the carnage on display. "Who exactly was his mentor, anyway? A walking flesh-blender?"

"Close guess, actually. He learned from Xelas." Arcanicus wasn't sure how he felt about the immediate understanding that settled into both rookies' faces at that revelation. He was of the opinion that perhaps the guild didn't need to be bone-chillingly scary to function effectively, but that put him in the minority of their leadership. The guild's current plan was built out of reestablishing precisely that horrific reputation, so Xelas and her methods were clearly a good fit for the organization.

As a spray of alien viscera landed on his shoes, Arcanicus muttered darkly under his breath. Carnage was one thing; they needed to teach him how to aim the consequences better. If the guild was going to be home to the world's greatest horrors, then Arcanicus could ensure they were well-trained unnatural disasters, if nothing else.



Moving the apartment building's residents around was surprisingly easy. One of the benefits to living in Ridge City: everyone was accustomed to meta-fights and evacuations. With minimal prompting, they were willing to accept the aid of a woman in what could be generously described as a makeshift costume. By opting to be "**Better lucky than good**," Cliché managed to avoid almost every threat as they walked down into the garage, depositing her neighbors into their respective concrete cubes or whatever ones were unoccupied. On the few occasions where someone did spot them,

her umbrella easily deflected any ranged attacks they sent, and soon, the attackers had one of the capes to worry about.

She tried hard to put Nexus and his cryptic warning out of her mind as she worked. There had been no sign of him since leaving the roof, but that offered little comfort when it came to a man who could appear from nowhere. Scary as Nexus was, he didn't appear to be taking an active role today, which made him more annoyance than threat. When everyone else was coming to kill, creepy predictions didn't carry quite the same oomph.

The scream caught her off guard. Having already checked all of the rooms down this hall, Cliché was heading back toward the roof to report a successful evacuation. It didn't sound like a mid-fight scream, especially considering she'd glimpsed Bahamut and Agent Quantum a floor above minutes prior. Maybe she'd missed someone, and they'd gotten caught? Except, something about that voice was almost... familiar. Umbrella at the ready, Cliché crept forward, taking each step with care until she came around a corner and nearly gasped in shock.

Tachyonic was down. Not just down, trying to crawl on his back, eyes tilted upward at the twisted face of the man staring down at him. Smoke drifted from the man's left arm, dark and gaunt all the way to the elbow. By the way Tachyonic was dragging his leg, this didn't seem like any sort of ploy; he'd been seriously injured. For someone with his skillset, Tachyonic was functionally out of the fight, a huge blow to the New Science Sentries' collective strength.

"It's such a pretty narrative. One man's genius breaks the very foundations of reality, ushering in a new age of limitless potential. The laws of physics and the universe are altered, allowing what was once impossible to become commonplace. Except it all ignores the simple truth that some things are *supposed* to be impossible. What was unleashed has far more capacity to corrupt, destroy, and ruin rather than elevate. How many monsters have risen out of our world, chasing or fueled by the power he unleashed?"

"So you're the good one? Going to tell me how, somehow, all of this is because *you* were really in the right? Look, you'll never have to sell me on Professor Quantum being a callous, cold, calculating asshole. But he still turns his power toward the greater good, so why don't you spare me the moralizing. I know who the superhero is between the two of you."

The man advanced, stomping down a foot next to Tachyonic's shin that shattered the wood beneath. Oh crap; he was strong on top of whatever was going on with his hand. Cliché leaned slightly forward, shifting her footing in case she needed to help. Thus far, the umbrella had been able to take everything thrown at it. Hopefully, this was not the day she discovered its limits.

"You're so young, barely more than a child. It's no wonder you still believe in such ridiculous concepts. There are no heroes in this world, super or otherwise. Only powerful people playing games to amuse themselves, the mundane serving as little more than pieces and prizes. The entire premise is a fabrication, a trick that lets them rule while upholding the illusion of service. The only difference between your people and the guild is that yours were more effective in seizing power."

Cliché said a small prayer of thanks in her heart to whoever the god of monologuing was, for they'd been blessed with a talker. That was time not spent maiming or killing; Tachyonic just needed to play into the rant and keep him going until help could arrive. Help other than her—someone with real power to swing around.

"I might be young, but you are categorically *wrong*." Tachyonic somehow managed to find a defiant expression, despite his prone, vulnerable position. "Are a lot of capes like that? Hell yes. Most of us are in this career for the wrong reasons, from pure ambition to having no normal job options. But there are some who live up to the word superhero, whose hearts are in exactly the right place, who take up this fight because they can't imagine standing by when they have the power to help. I know it with absolute certainty; it has been my privilege to work under just such a person."

A sharp hiss and crackle drew Cliché's attention to the looming man's left arm, which was sending up even more smoke. Strangely, the skin along his arm turned crisp, then flaked away, unlike any transformation she'd seen before. It was more like he was burning off an outer shell of flesh.

Leaning down, his right hand flew out, snaring Tachyonic by the skull, holding his head locked in place. "Do you still think he's going to save you? That there's any hope you will all make it out of this?"

"The entire point of being a superhero is giving people hope even in the most dire of lost situations," Tachyonic replied. "Maybe he won't make it in time to save me, but he's absolutely going to stop you."



They stayed like that for a long moment, until the grip on Tachyonic's skull was suddenly released. "Very brave, little pawn. Trying to goad me into killing you in the hopes of taking away my hostage. Your friends still would have died, but I will admit, it might have been harder to draw them all in. Now, I shall teach you the cost of bravery. Everything below your right knee seems an adequate price."

He lifted his smoking left arm, and Cliché realized her bystander time was officially over. Either she let this happen or stood up: both options represented a choice. Praying dearly that the mask and goggle combo adequately hid her face, Cliché dove out from her hiding spot, racing forward with umbrella at the ready.

Whether it was uncertainty as to who she was or merely confusion at the motley ensemble running in his direction, the man actually did pause to see what the hell was happening. It was enough of a gap for Cliché to leap between him and Tachyonic, popping her umbrella out to full extension, barely fitting inside the narrow confines of the hallway.

"Get out of here! He's too strong." Tachyonic tried to send her away; however, the effort was significantly compromised by his inability to stand or walk.

"I think that's in our favor. The worse I am in comparison, the luckier I should be." Cliché wasn't entirely sure if that was how her current saying actually worked, but it felt like it *could* be true as an interpretation. If the power really was shaped by her perceptions of it, then that was how she chose for the phrase to interact with the world.

Then again, if she was wrong, it probably wouldn't take too long to figure out.

The man examined Cliché once with detached interest before coldly remarking, "You are not a New Science Sentry. There is no purpose in killing you slowly." His left hand slashed down, intercepted by the umbrella as the bone-like digits raked off what should have been nothing more than dark fabric. Mercifully, the makeshift shield held, though the reaction that came next was completely unexpected.

"*What?!?*" The man bellowed, his voice ringing off the walls around them, all composure suddenly gone. He struck again, that smoking hand scratching at the handheld barrier between them, only to slide harmlessly off. "This can't be. No mere object can withstand my corrosion. Even the skin I wear is temporary. You... *dare* to challenge me?"

The next blow that came was not a scratch; instead, it was like a sledgehammer. Having raised up his arms, the man struck with tremendous force, driving Cliché and her legs deep into the wooden floor. Snapping sounds were her only warning before suddenly, there was no ground beneath her feet. The stomp he'd delivered earlier had substantially weakened the structure; this second blow was more than the old building could bear.

Through the air she and Tachyonic tumbled, down onto the unexpectedly soft landing pile of blankets and pillows. They'd ended up in a bedroom a floor below, the lush mattress easily breaking both of their falls. Up above, she could still see the man, staring down through the hole he'd just accidentally made, twisted in rage and glaring down at both of them. Well, she was certainly on his radar now.

"The hell just happened?" Tachyonic fought his way out from under a pile of pillows, rising back to a seated position just before they heard the gentle *thud* of another body hitting the ground, their attacker landing only feet away.

"You managed to buy yourself another few minutes." Everything from his left shoulder down was smoking now, as were small sections of his face where the peeling process had begun. "That's all your vain struggling managed to accomplish."

This time, there was nothing gentle about the noise that rang out from the floor upon landing. Given the new form's size and muscles, it was no surprise the wood struggled to uphold what crashed down heavily upon it, and if rage had any mass, then Agent Quantum would have caused the floorboards to buckle right then and there.

"They also made enough noise to be easily found." Agent Quantum looked across the room to Tachyonic's injured form. The anger hardened as his gaze turned to the smoking-armed attacker. Cliché had never seen an expression like that on his face, in or out of costume. It was, curiously, the first time she'd even noticed any resemblance at all between Agent and Professor Quantum.

Despite the evident fury, he still didn't come out of the gate swinging. "You get one chance: surrender, and come in quietly. Don't try to fight me right now. I'm not at all confident I can hold back."

"He's our weakness!" Tachyonic hurriedly yelled from the bed. "Don't let him touch you—it messes with our abilities. Just get the others clear. He

won't stop until he has us all."

"Well, yes and no," the man corrected, his calm voice and face once more fixed in place. Whatever dark impulses Cliché had stirred up, Agent Quantum was clearly of higher priority. "The weakness part is true, and I fully intend to do some killing, but only you are truly essential, Agent Quantum. Only you carry *his* blood."

Up above, Cliché could make out the forms of Medley and Bahamut. They must have heard the noise, as well. Perhaps they were waiting for the right moment to strike, which she hoped would arrive soon. Tempting as it was to teleport out, she wasn't going anywhere until at least her roommates were present. Besides, at least here, she could influence things slightly. She just hoped it would be for the better.

"That mean you'll let the others go?" Agent Quantum asked.

"Obviously not. My point is just that I don't especially care about them, so it's possible they could escape. Flee and cower—that will shame the Science Sentries brand nearly as well as their deaths. That means the longer you 'distract' me, the better their chances of escape."

Lifting his arms, Agent Quantum took a position that clearly indicated a fight was about to begin. "Seems we both believe ourselves to be the stronger in this fight. How 'bout we skip the bluster and find out who's right?"

"You lack his prudence and intelligence, yet you managed to retain the arrogance. I shall take great pleasure in this."

Agent Quantum charged, and the battle was on.

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## Chapter 114

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The noise was fading, not that it mattered. Zerle Salvrin remained enraged, swinging like he intended to knock Fornax's skull from his shoulders. The cries for help from his people, all beyond his reach, had done their job and rattled his certainty. Had Ivan been the one running this show, he would have ended things soon after. To his thinking, it was enough. Sadly, for Zerle Salvrin, this was a Fornax mission, and he was only just beginning to have fun. Besides, this show wasn't really for Zerle Salvrin, and Fornax couldn't start the conclusion until the star performance had occurred.

A dull ringing echoed through the room as Zerle Salvrin's fists collided with the wall, failing yet again to land a blow on Fornax. The Wrexwren anatomy and martial art was certainly unique, involving tactics that had demanded time to fully grasp, but Fornax had been born in battle. His entire life until the change was nothing but fighting: constantly, endlessly, without even the hope of it ceasing. Adapting to new forms of attack was one of the reasons Ivan had been the lone survivor, and some habits were far too ingrained to be weathered away by a few mere years of peace.

"While my world chips away at your title, I can move on to breaking the next of your foundations: that strength in which you place so much value. Tell me, Zerle Salvrin, were you the strongest of your people?"

Zerle Salvrin was in no mood for chitchat. He kept pressing the attack, limbs swirling in all manner of directions, like an inescapable cloud. Fornax struck directly through the attempt, knocking two arms aside as he sent the Wrexwren hurtling back hard into the wall. "I asked you a question. Don't get boring on me, or I'll have to find other ways to entertain myself."

Whether it was the actual threat, or just the desire for a few seconds of rest, Zerle Salvryn eventually replied as he slowly pulled himself back to standing. “I am among the elite, yet there are greater threats still among my people. Do not think this will save your planet. Even if our forces are driven back, the Wrexwren will never stop.”

“Oh?” Fornax didn’t sound as if he was afraid of the prospect. In fact, he was bordering on excitement. “How I wish you were right about that. What I wouldn’t give for an endless stream of your people coming to Earth, providing me with new fun. Because I am *not* the strongest of my people.”

He pointed overhead, to where the screen showed Lodestar glowing brighter than before, still attempting to fight back the cosmic horror on a crash course for the Earth’s sun. “Our planet is like a pressure cooker, and that is the lid. We host a constant building of power and force that should spill forth into the greater universe, except for the insurmountable barrier that holds us all back. It spurs us on to greater heights, building more pressure as we try and fail to overtake her. As iron sharpens iron, meta sharpens meta, all so we can break our blades on that incomprehensible wall named Lodestar.”

“You believe weakness is a thing to boast of?” Zerle Salvryn came in for another round, but this time, Fornax didn’t wait for the attack. He dashed forward, hitting his opponent in the torso yet again. He didn’t permit the alien to fly back, however. Instead, he took hold of one of the four arms, pulling it taut until it nearly separated from the body.

“I don’t think you get the point. My species hasn’t been dominating the galaxy for untold years, attacking less-advanced cultures and calling that superiority strength. We are a combative, violent race that struggles endlessly to be mightier. In just fighting with each other and trying to reach that impossible standard set by our champion, we have already grown well past the point where the Wrexwren could ever have been a real threat.”

Kicks came from the multiple legs, but Fornax didn’t bother trying to dodge. He let the blows rain down, wards blocking most of the damage, yet not all. It was a gamble, allowing some injury now in the hopes it would strip away Zerle Salvryn’s will to fight. After telling him he was weak, refusing to show any reaction to the alien’s blows only drove the point further home.

“If we are no threat, then why did your greatest defender come to meet us?” Zerle Salvryn demanded. It might have been a real question, or a ploy

to take whatever the Wrexwren version of a breather was. Either way, that was a good enough opening to Fornax.

“She is the world’s true superhero, and will defend it from any threat, big or small. It’s why the people of that planet can live such peaceful lives despite the chaos and madness of their reality: deep down, they all know that they have Lodestar’s protection. Which is the same reason why I’m up here today. Because you... *don’t*.”

The sound was wetter than he’d expected, given all the rough armor on the exterior, but it turned out the Wrexwren had a goopier inside than anticipated, at least around their limbs. Whatever noises Zerle Salvrin was making, there was no direct translation available, and perhaps that was a small mercy.

Not letting go of his prize, Fornax slapped Zerle Salvrin across the head with the newly detached arm, still flinging green goop all over the place. “*You* don’t have her protection, mighty Zerle. Since you came declaring war, none of your people do. What you considered an invasion, we think of as a pleasant diversion. You’ve given the Earth’s metas some new amusement, toys we can break to our heart’s content without fear of the blinding light interrupting the fun.”

Throwing his head back, Fornax let out a good old-fashioned villainous cackle. It came naturally, as did every part of this. That was the problem, being Fornax was *too* easy. There was no helping it for now, though. Making this work meant selling the part, so he allowed the dark impulses to wash over him. “You thought she was protecting us from the greater galaxy, didn’t you? Never once did it occur to you that perhaps Earth is home to innumerable monsters that would chew through what the rest of the cosmos considers to be threats. She’s not protecting *us* from the greater universe. She’s protecting the rest of you from things like *me*. That cute little ploy with your giant monster, what you likely thought to be a stroke of genius, was really just you sending away the only being who could have saved your people from this outcome.”

Another smack with the arm, more to horrify than to hurt. The job wasn’t yet done, and wouldn’t be until Lodestar completed her task. Fornax could break many things—he truly was an artist of the medium—but destroying hope was another matter. For that, he needed the power of a Lodestar. Until then, Fornax would simply have to amuse himself further.

“You lie... this is a trick...” Zerle Salvryn didn’t have quite the same confidence he had earlier in the fight—even his anger was being drowned out by uncertainty. They’d have to rekindle that flame soon, though not quite yet. Fornax preferred to hit him with the heaviest blows in rapid succession.

“Lying is for people too weak to own their truths. I am Fornax, one of the planet’s strongest combatants, renowned killer, and infamous villain. No tricks, no deceit. I’m just better. The only reason you aren’t dead yet is that I haven’t finished destroying you. Well, that...”

The blow was sudden and savage, a direct kick to the Wrexwren’s leg that completely shattered the lower half of the limb. Zerle Salvryn went sprawling, down to three functional appendages on both the upper and lower halves of his body. More harsh whistle-screams rang out as Fornax walked around him slowly, savoring each screech.

“That,” Fornax continued, “and I like the funny noises you make. Let’s see just how entertaining a Zerle can really be.”



“This might be getting a little violent.” Juan reached for the remote, intending to click away from the stream on the television. The hideout Ivan had sent Janet and the others to resembled a simple hotel on the fringes of a farming museum—not that there were any tours going on, given the day’s events. Everyone was huddled inside, though no Wrexwren ships had been seen anywhere near their vicinity. Or if they were, the security forces were handling it.

Janet’s hand moved before she’d thought it all through, snatching the remote away first. “You’re right. This is probably a bit much for Beth. Why don’t you two go to the lobby and get us some lunch?” She couldn’t turn away. Part of this was on her—she’d told Ivan the world needed to fear Fornax again. If anyone owed him a duty as witness, it was Janet. Besides, for all that had passed between them, some shard of her would always love Ivan, even if it was only the pieces of him she saw reflected in their children. He was fighting for the fate of the world and his family—at the very least, she could watch him do it.

“What about me?” Rick asked.

A month ago, it would have been such a simple question. Make him leave, keep him in the dark, as far from the truth as humanly possible. Now, he'd begun to unravel the shawl draped over their past. Sooner or later, there was a very real chance Rick was going to discover who his father was. He was going to hear horrible things about the man he called "Dad"—and worse, most of them would be true. Today would do little to alter that perception; watching Fornax torture a living creature, invader or not, would leave a sour taste in many people's mouths. Then again, there would also only be so many times he might get to see his father helping to save the world, and whether people liked the methods or not, Fornax was pitching in. Based on the horrific stream of cries from the Wrexwren in that broadcast, it seemed as if the entire guild was.

"It's up to you," Janet decided and declared in the same breath. "Violent as it is, I can't say this isn't a historic moment for our planet. There is some value in watching it unfold." Rick's journey of discovery had thus far been largely self-directed, so Janet decided to let that trend continue.

"I'll stay and watch. Finding out Fornax was alive was crazy enough. I never thought I'd get to see him cutting loose. Where the hell has he been all these years?" The flicker was brief, dispelled instantly by a brain not willing to contemplate such truths, yet Janet saw it all the same. A moment of concern, terror, on Rick's face as he'd briefly entertained what no doubt seemed like a ridiculous possibility. Pity for him; the longer he mulled it over, the less implausible it would sound.

As Juan and Beth headed out, Janet changed her position. Moving from the chair, she sat down on one of the bed's edges, next to Rick. If asked, she'd have said it was to get a better view—except Rick didn't ask. Probably because he'd reached that conclusion already, or the fight on-screen was simply too engrossing.

Or, deep down, Rick knew why she'd moved into easy hugging range and didn't yet want to face it. Janet, for her part, said nothing more. She didn't trust herself not to give everything away, even with how close Rick was to the truth. All she could do was be there for her son no matter if he chose discovery or ignorance, and try to mend what remained if his entire world fell down around him.





Lozora slipped along, moving toward the sound of the fracas. Her employer should be where the action was by this point. The few advances she'd gotten were fine, but the bulk of her pay still hung in the balance, so he'd better have managed to make it on time. At least she didn't have to worry about him losing upon arrival. There were capes who could potentially deal with him as a threat—temporarily, if nothing else—but they were all handling the much larger issue of an alien invasion. It was the most ludicrous, over-the-top distraction she'd ever even heard of, and it had been a large chunk of what convinced her to take the job. Anyone with that kind of ambition would be fun to watch whether they succeeded or flamed out spectacularly.

Her slender limbs made little sound as she crept, peering around a corner to spot Medley and some humanoid-dragon meta both looking through a hole in the floor. Dollars to cents, that would be where she found her target. How to approach was more complicated. Medley was no pushover, and the dragon certainly possessed the build of a bruiser. As a physical-based meta herself, two-on-one would put her at a disadvantage, even if they were individually weaker than she. Part of surviving meant avoiding needless risks, so Lozora eased back out of their sight.

The retreat lasted until she felt cold metal press into her back, and saw flashing lights in the corner of her eye.

“Tell us who the fuck you are right now, or I remodel your torso with an outside view. Whatever is left, Plasmodia can dice into pieces.”

“Hephaestus, that isn't how superheroes work.” Cyber Geek stepped into view, some device that looked like a lantern with earmuffs fading back to sparks. That explained how they'd snuck up on her, though it didn't really help the current predicament.

“Someone just captured a New Science Sentry and threatened to cut off his head. You'd better harden up fast, Cyber Geek. These people are not playing around.” The voice from behind, Hephaestus, was spot on, not that Lozora could tell any of them that.

Raising her hands slowly, Lozora made her posture as nonthreatening as possible. “I'm sorry! I'm sorry. I didn't mean to trespass, but there were aliens and a bunch of people with weird weapons, so I was trying to find somewhere to hide. Please, I can leave. I don't want any trouble.”

“Horseshit. You, a clear meta-human, broke into a building surrounded by a violent battle in an attempt to escape danger? Tell me neither of you

capas are buying this.”

Plasmodia stepped forward, the sharp light emitting from her hand forcing Lozora to blink and look away. “Honestly, no. I don’t believe it either.” The light suddenly dimmed, and Plasmodia shifted her hand away. “But being a superhero isn’t just about protecting honest people. She doesn’t have a weapon and didn’t try to attack either of our allies. At worst, I think we have a robber with bad taste. At best, a civilian with terrible luck.”

“Either way, you’re staying with us,” Cyber Geek declared. “It’s too dangerous to let you wander off if you really are a civilian, and too risky for us if you’re not. Stay close, out of the fight, and when this is all over we’ll see you to safety.”

Almost incapable of believing her luck, Lozora waited for the coldness on her back to move. It finally did, though not before the helmet came within touching distance, brushing against the side of her head. “Give me a reason. I dare you.”

The voice didn’t try to whisper, which made the need for proximity curious, but when the threat was delivered, Lozora found herself not being poked by the weapon, which she considered excellent progress. Not only did it sound like she’d found her employer, Lozora had also procured a front-row seat. If things went south, she might even be willing to jump in and help the plans stay running smoothly.

For an additional fee, of course.

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## Chapter 115

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Agent Quantum's swing went wide, sailing over the strange man's head as he easily side-stepped the attempted blow. Crawling, Tachyonic tried to make it to the edge of the bed, unsure of what he'd even do once he was off it, but certain that he had to try *something*. He'd already known their enemy was powerful. Now, they were learning things was even worse: this bizarre man also had training.

Thus far, he hadn't even delivered a single blow to Agent Quantum. There had been no need, when he could dodge every attack. It wasn't that he was just fast, however. For all the capabilities taken from Tachyonic by being hobbled, he could still perceive things at near super-speed. Watching the fight in slow motion, it was easier to notice the small details, like how this man wasn't actually quicker than Agent Quantum. He started reacting to the attack before it actually arrived, which could mean prophetic abilities, making them all the more screwed. Except sometimes, he had to tweak his dodges on the fly, meaning he didn't know exactly what was coming, only the general shape. Strangely, the attacks that came closest were when Agent Quantum got sloppy and broke his form.

Taking it all in and processing through a sped-up brain, Tachyonic quickly reached the most viable explanation he could find. "Agent Quantum! This guy knows our playbook. That's how he's reading your moves."

"*Your* playbook?" A hideous glare twisted around to Tachyonic, hatred flowing like the smoke drifting from cracks in his face. "These tactics are no more yours than the team name or costumes. I have fought the real

Science Sentries, tracked their every development through the decades. If the true creators of your techniques were unable to defeat me with them, the sickly imitations will fare no better.”

The speech bought Agent Quantum a few moments to breathe, which he wisely utilized. Sounds came from overhead, and Tachyonic caught blurs of movement from Bahamut and Medley, along with what appeared to be more goons. Right, there were still a few stragglers around. Those two were probably holding the perimeter. He looked away just as a flash tugged at the corner of his eyes, but the smoking-armed man was much too dangerous to leave unwatched.

When Agent Quantum came again, he was moving differently. Not nearly as smooth or polished, he’d broken out of his usual form and was shifting more to a brawling style. Unrefined, true, but also less predictable. The first punch still missed, but the second managed to land. A solid uppercut that caught their enemy on the chin, resulting in a *snap* that brought warmth to Tachyonic’s heart... until he saw Agent Quantum grip his own fist in pain.

Before Agent Quantum could retreat, his opponent’s right hand snapped out, grabbing him by the shoulder and squeezing so hard it drove the big cape to his knees. “I’m afraid hitting me is only the first hurdle. You’d also have to be strong enough to inflict damage. Seems we’ve reached your limits already. How disappointing, and after your dear friend gave such an impassioned speech about how you’d stop me for certain.”

Agent Quantum tried to struggle, but it was no use. He was simply far weaker than his enemy. This was the difference in strength that existed in the meta-world.

Tachyonic pulled toward the end of the bed where that umbrella woman was huddled up, her odd yet effective shield fully extended, just in case. Nearly to the edge, Tachyonic had to jerk his head back as a fully masked face appeared in front of him.

Hunkering low, his small stature at last a boon, Presto put a finger to where his lips would be, pointing up through the hole as he slipped an arm around both of them. Tachyonic began to object, until Presto quickly whispered, “We have to get you both out so there’s room to fight. Why do you think the other heavies are waiting?”

Knowing it was the right tactic, Tachyonic bit his tongue. They weren’t running. They were getting out of the way... no matter how much it felt like

abandoning a friend.

“Look, Agent Quantum. Your friends are so quick to leave you, perhaps there’s more in common with you and the original than I suspected.”

It was a good thing Presto looked up out of the hole and teleported at that moment, as Tachyonic might have tried to claw his way over. They popped out barely past the perimeter of the hole; at the angles Presto was working with, this was the best line-of-sight he could manage. All three collapsed in a heap, but Tachyonic was on his back, scoping things out before the others.

Throughout the hall there were a few newly downed crooks, as well as the entirety of their AHC forces, minus Agent Quantum below. Medley was already halfway through the hole, Bahamut right behind. Flanking either side of the floor’s entrance were Hephaestus and Plasmodia, both with arms up and energy at the ready. Further down one hallway, Tachyonic spotted Cold Shoulder forming an ice wall, cutting off potential avenues of attack, just like she’d done when they were controlling the flow of crooks getting in. Above him, Hat Trick and Cyber Geek were both looking down, the former wearing her concern plain on every part of her face not covered by a mask.

“Can you do anything?” She wasn’t talking to him, instead to Cyber Geek, who was making motions in the air like there was something only he could see.

“Got an idea, just haven’t had much chance to test it.” Cyber Geek produced a sci-fi-looking implement in a shower of blue sparks and numbers. “No outright healing items I’ve tried have worked on anyone because they were consumables, but status effects are another matter, like with my freeze ray. This is the Rally Rod from *Galactic Conquest 9*, an item that temporarily numbs pain and boosts the energy of every troop you use it on. It won’t fully heal you, but it might get you back in the fight for a little while.”

“Do it.” Tachyonic had to force himself to slow down enough to make the words comprehensible to these two.

A flicker of hesitation from Cyber Geek. “Thing is, I haven’t tried it yet, and in-game, it’s not described a pleasant experience—”

“My best friend is down there getting stomped because *I* got my stupid ass captured. Use the goddamn staff, *now!*” Medley and Bahamut were already through, yet Tachyonic knew it wouldn’t be enough. That guy was

just too strong. Even getting momentarily healed, he had no idea what difference his speed could even make in the fight.

None of which mattered. There was no way in hell he was letting Austin face a match like that without his backup. He held on to that thought as Cyber Geek's staff made contact and the incredible waves of pain began to flow from his ankle. It was all that kept him from passing out immediately.



Medley was only a few steps in front of Bahamut, yet he sprang with such ferocity upon landing that he reached the target substantially ahead of her. The strange man was unbothered by their appearance—given the wide smile on his smoking face, he might have even been happy to see them. Medley's first round of blows were taken without flinching, before his opponent delivered a single backhand that sent the sizable cape sailing into, and through, one of the apartment walls. He crashed in the kitchen, creating a cacophony of pots and pans.

Slowing her own charge, Bahamut reconsidered the plan. That kind of strength was no joke, especially considering Medley's general heft. Between that trick and the fact that their target was still holding Agent Quantum prone, it was evident they'd yet to push this stranger anywhere close to his limits. That didn't mean all was lost; they did have a rudimentary plan in place, but brute force wouldn't be enough.

"The guild's new dragon is here, too, I see. You may want to scamper home, little lizard. I'm no more afraid of your organization than I am of theirs. Riding the reputations of your betters will do you no good in the real world."

It was an obvious attempt to get under her skin, but it presumed she'd put far more sense of self into her villainy and strength than Beverly had even approached. That those were the targets he went for first was informative, however. People often attacked what they considered to be their own weak spots on others, because that was what they thought of as being most vulnerable.

"You've got some nerve to talk about riding reputations. How many pawns did you need just to make it this far and get Agent Quantum in your clutches? All that effort to take on what you call a sickly imitation of the

real team. Guess that makes *you* an imitation of the original Science Sentries' actual villains. No wonder you had to settle for going after the kiddie version when you couldn't cut it against the real deal."

Facially, there was little change. Dermatologically, it was a terrifying show as the skin along his neck and face rapidly eroded, revealing gaunt, dark features. The more of him that was exposed, the surer Bahamut became that there was nothing other than bones waiting to greet them. It made the smile even more horrifying as a corner of the mouth fell away completely.

To her surprise, his next move was not to bolt over to her. Instead, he released Agent Quantum, who darted away and back to his feet in seconds. "How silly of me. I was caught up in the action, eyes on my prize, and nearly forgot to relish the experience. In front of a guild representative, no less. You're quite right. This demands far more cruelty and torment. I shall play with you all for a bit longer, with one caveat. Agent Quantum, if you run, I'm going to kill everyone here, then start lopping off the heads of civilians, one per hour, until we finish this."

Whoever this guy was, nothing gave the impression he was bluffing. Bahamut's eyes flickered to Agent Quantum, noting the way his arm wasn't hanging quite right. The grip on his shoulder had left damage, and that wasn't even with the smoking arm. A single blow from this guy could take them out of the fight, or cave their very skulls in, depending on how much he put into it. They were outside their league right now, and all of them could feel it. But life wasn't merely an equation with numbers plugged in. There was strategy and tactics to consider. Plus, they had the advantage of greater forces, and that opened up more options than working alone.

Rustling from the other room was all the warning they got before Medley came bursting out of the kitchen rubble, bounding on all fours as he came at the enemy. Bahamut charged, too, ready this time to make it a multi-pronged assault. Since she and Medley had no experience working together or fighting alongside one another, they'd elected for a simple division of combat labor.

As Medley went low, aiming for the legs, Bahamut went high, sending precise blows toward the torso. There was an uncomfortable crumpling as Medley hit the legs, his body collapsing in on itself from the resistance. Still, with claws dug in for grip, he managed to force the back of their enemy's knee slightly forward, shifting his center of balance. Seeing the

opening, Bahamut let loose a real punch, not holding back one bit. If she blasted the walls with his brains, then that was a good turn so far as she was concerned. Not one worth worrying about, however, as the strike sent pain tearing through her arm. It was like she'd hit a steel beam, except she suspected that would have hurt less.

For as strong as he was, the enemy did still use two legs to stand on. That meant shifting his balance in one direction while pushing hard in another was enough to leave him unsteady. On their own, that probably would have been the limit of their offensive, but there was still one more ally to account for. Agent Quantum came barreling in, showing no fear despite his recent failings, following up Bahamut's blow with one of his own.

The trio of attacks was enough to do what on their own none could have managed: they knocked the stranger onto his back. Unfortunately, the plan had to adapt. Originally, this was when they would have helped Agent Quantum escape, getting everyone out and to safety. After that ultimatum, she had a hunch he wouldn't go that easily. There was one idea from the old plan that could be repurposed, however: the way they'd planned to hold this guy off if he tried to follow.

Reaching down, Bahamut grabbed the man by his ankles, planning to easily chunk him through the air. Instead, she felt as if she were lifting a boulder. He was dense in a way that wasn't quite weight, yet still made him hard to move. Putting everything she could manage into it, Bahamut used her whole body to force the throw, weakly slamming him into the wall at the far end of the room.

Upon landing, he rose to his feet, brushing some of the dust from what remained of his shirt. The left section had largely burned away, revealing that the smoking bits of flesh were now well past the left shoulder and into the torso. "If you're about done, I think I've given you ample chance for your turn at offense."

"That's wasn't my offense," Bahamut corrected. "That was just optimal repositioning."

He had almost enough time to realize the throw had placed him almost directly under the hole in the ceiling. Had he made it in time, that revelation might not have mattered much, given that the toughest fighters from every team were already down with him. But he didn't share in Bahamut's knowledge, namely that they had a pair of long-range damage dealers who



were positioned right overhead, ready to fire if their opponent had tried to pursue.

She didn't even have to call out the order. Both of the women watching had pieced it together; they'd heard the same threat to Agent Quantum as Bahamut. From above, multiple streams of concentrated energy rained down. Hephaestus's beams were familiar by this point, and also visibly outclassed by the ridiculous torrent of energy flowing from Plasmodia. Clearly, she didn't appreciate her team leader being threatened.

The combined assault was too much for Bahamut to look at; the guy's body was essentially glowing. At last, the lights faded, and Bahamut was able to blink her way back to vision. In a way, she wished she hadn't, because the first thing she saw was that their opponent was still standing. Only, he didn't look much like the one they'd started the battle with.

Almost all the skin was gone, save for a few patches here and there, one hanging on just above his right eye, if it could be called that. An inky, dark orb easily mistaken for a void filled the socket, resting in a face with no nose, ears, or other decoration. Only a dark sinew ran between the black limbs, not like any form of muscle Bahamut had encountered before. Smoke rose from his entire body now, and she noticed the ground where he stood was warping and cracking.

There was no more smile—Bahamut realized there had never been one to start. Only a skull's haunting, unmoving grin with a thin veneer of false flesh stretched atop. She really hoped the craftier members of their groups had something in mind. Her well of ideas ran dry just as he took a step forward.

“As I was saying, I think you've had a fair shot at offense, and should now realize just how impossible the fight is. However, I'm not done playing yet, so let's make this a bit more fun. Something classic seems in order. Should you manage to guess my name, I'll grant your wish and let everyone go. Even Agent Quantum.”

The words might have been heartening, if not for the malicious glee absolutely dripping from each word. No one was even surprised when he continued. “Just be warned, I take a toll of flesh for every attempt. Try as many times as you like, for as long as you can bear it.”

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## Chapter 116

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Nothing. Not a scratch, not a dent, not a crack. Even Ivan had shown a small mark on his hand, and that was from a much earlier model of this blaster. Granted, he wasn't exactly in full combat mode at the time, but this guy hadn't employed any tricks that Hephaestus could discern either. It sure seemed like he'd just taken the entire blast of energy, near point-blank, without flinching. Given the intensity in her attack and the shock on her face, Hephaestus had a hunch Plasmodia was experiencing similar feelings.

Noises came from down the hall, where Cyber Geek and Cold Shoulder were taking care of another batch of straggling enemies. Hat Trick and Presto were still nearby; their powers tended to be more situational, so they'd been stuck guarding the unexpected trespasser. While it was impossible to read Presto's face through the mask, Hat Trick's expression made it clear she felt as flummoxed as they did. Not far away, Cliché was on her phone, scrolling like the wind, though what she was looking at, Hephaestus had no clue. By virtue of distraction, Cliché was one of two who missed the terrifying display of durability. The other was Tachyonic, who was slowly coming around, but was still visibly out of it from Cyber Geek's staff.

"We didn't even annoy him. He's ignoring us." Plasmodia looked down at her hands, still glowing with what should be deadly power.

It was an experience Hephaestus had known was coming, yet the arrival was no more pleasant to endure: she was against someone above her abilities. Dealing with people like Ivan and the council, it was impossible to delude herself into believing her current meta-suit and some fire powers

would be enough to overcome every challenge. Some metas existed on an entirely different scale than she did, for now. The man below was obviously one such example.

As panic swept through the others, she forced herself to stay calm. Terrifying as the moment was, all was not yet lost. Because the truth was, her original gift wasn't beam-shooting gauntlets, or a homemade combat suit, or fire powers, or even meta-genius. From the very beginning, her one true talent was the capacity to look at a situation and keep thinking until she found a way through: intelligence born of willfully stubborn determination. This smoking bone-man had bested the suit. That wasn't the same as beating her.

What did she have to work with? One cape with the powers of a stage magician, one with line-of-sight teleportation, a living plasma battery, topped off by commanders of ice and video games, respectively. She also had Cliché, who might be handy if they could hit upon the right saying. For most of those present, Hephaestus knew too little about their abilities and training to make proper use of them, but as she looked from her own hands to Plasmodia, an idea took shape. The same idea, in a way, only reformed and hopefully improved.

Below them, Bahamut tried to knock the legs out from under the enemy with a sweep, only to have her own leg kicked back so hard there was no question the bone would be fractured. Fast as she healed in that form, it would still hurt like hell. And that was nothing compared to what might happen if this guy really let loose. He was toying with them, openly so, and once the fun dried up, what came next wouldn't be pretty. Agent Quantum and Medley ran in to help, but Hephaestus already knew how it would end. They were fighting a losing battle, unless she could change the equation.

"Anyone have guesses on the name?" Hat Trick asked. "I don't think he'd really let us go, but it might give them some space, or create an opportunity."

"No, which is troubling." Presto sounded unlike himself. This might have been the first time Hephaestus heard him take a fight seriously. "I've studied the Science Sentries more than anyone but the most devoted superhero expert, and this guy is ringing zero bells. Even though he acts like he's been around forever."

While this wasn't the time to say it, Hephaestus was having similar thoughts. Someone with this much power should have left an impression

throughout history; the fact that he was such an unknown meant that either he'd been working in secret all this time, or another power had wiped out any traces of him. Neither boded well for what they were facing.

"Doesn't matter. When we guess it, he'll just find another excuse. Nobody having this much fun is just going to let the game end, especially after a plan this complicated to get here. If we want this asshole gone, the only way is to drive him out." Hephaestus pointed to Plasmodia, who was slowly coming back to herself. "I need your help."

"For what? Soldering? I just hit him with the strongest blast I've got. I could go bigger, but if that intensity didn't work, then... there's nothing I can do." Plasmodia was also hitting the wall of her own limitations, and wasn't nearly as prepared for it as Hephaestus had been.

Ordinarily, she'd have let the cape get over it in her own time, except Hephaestus needed Plasmodia if her idea had even a chance of working. "Why? Because your power doesn't work? You fucking capes. It's always about the abilities. Who gives a shit if he's got us beat on that angle? We've got limbs, lungs, and most of all, brains. He's stronger than us, fine. Let's make ourselves stronger than him. Meta or not, we're all humans at our base level, and there is nothing more human than using tools and wit to overcome a challenge outside our own abilities."

She noticed Presto start to do a mock-clap, then halt himself. Perhaps because he agreed with the sentiment or just appreciated the impact it was having. Plasmodia no longer looked so unsure; instead, her face was creasing in anger. It might have been more ideal if that rage was pointed down into the hole, but Hephaestus would take the progress she could get.

"How the hell are we supposed to do that? I watched your attack do just as much nothing as mine, so it's not like you've got an ace up your sleeve."

"Funny you should mention sleeves." Hoping this wouldn't be a time when she looked back with deep regret, Hephaestus released the interlocking systems on her left gauntlet, reaching over to pull it free from the suit with her right. The removal of a suit piece revealed her hand and forearm, covered entirely by the costume she'd donned before her suit. Staying concealed was still ideal, as it would keep anyone from realizing Hephaestus was a woman, which made keeping her identity secret so much easier.

Lifting up the device, Hephaestus nodded to it. "If I work fast, I can retool my own blaster. Get rid of everything except for the amplification

systems, put all of it into making the strongest shot possible. The more powerful a beam we start with, the greater the final output.”

“Who knows if that will even work? Or how long it will take?”

Plasmodia couldn't keep her eyes out of the hole, where they could see Agent Quantum take a particularly bad blow that sent him spinning. “If I went down there now, I couldn't do anything, could I? I'd just be another target.”

“Let him take a crack at it,” Presto said. “Not like he's trying to mess with any of our gear, and as you said, at this point, what do we risk? Even reaching out to try to teleport that guy felt like lifting a mountain. I'd probably explode my heart getting him across the street. It's all I can do to minimize damage.”

Paying closer attention, Hephaestus realized that Presto was indeed doing more than throwing cursory looks at the trespasser in their care. When one of the downstairs combatants got knocked toward anything too dangerous or sharp, he would shift them over slightly, conserving energy while keeping the wounds they took as limited as he could.

“Anything.” This voice didn't come from any that had been speaking. It belonged to Tachyonic, who had finally managed to bring himself back to consciousness. “Try anything. Doesn't have to be a good plan. Doesn't have to be a smart one. If it might work, that's enough.” Sweating from the effort of sudden injury and temporary recovery, Tachyonic struggled to his feet, using the wall to lean on and discovering his ankle would tolerate the weight of a leg once more, albeit barely.

“I am not letting that bastard win. We save our friends, which means stopping this threat. Find a way, if you can. It's the most any of us can do.” With barely a glance down to aim for the bed, Tachyonic leapt through the hole in the ground, reentering the fray as soon as he was able. There were bursts of speed as he scrambled off the bed, but he was definitely not back to full strength.

Shuffling through her sleeves and vest, Hat Trick sorted an array of magical items, plainly searching for anything that might be of aid. Her hands fell upon the wand, terror flickering in her gaze. “I've never used actual attack magic before. It would be a risk, but he might be vulnerable.”

“Knowing the way your new tricks tend to go before you master them, that might not be the best use of us,” Presto suggested. “I know how you're feeling. Getting stuck on the sidelines is the worst. Welcome to being a

support member: you have to watch the people you care about take the risks you aren't able to."

Those words, more than anything else, seemed to convince Plasmodia as she listened to them talk. "Hell with it. Sure, let's try your plan. If it fails, we're in exactly the same situation as right now. Just hurry. I think our enemy is getting bored."

"I'll work fast, but it's still going to take a minute." More than a minute, really. While she'd loaded up the suit with tools for repair and modifications in the field, these were still less ideal conditions than a lab. Add in that she'd essentially be working one-handed, with her other in the gauntlet, and things would be even slower. That was what she expected, anyway.

The second set of hands were familiar, largely because Tori recognized the high-end leather gloves around them. After all, she'd been there when Beverly loaned Chloe the accessories to complete her ensemble. Cliché was smiling nervously at Hephaestus, phone finally put away. "Don't worry. I think I found a way to help." Looking down again, she blinked, then pulled off the device hiding her eyes, setting them to the side. "Probably easier without the ultra-telescope goggles, though."

"Much as I appreciate the sentiment, this is specialized equipment that demands expertise-level knowledge and skill to work with." It was as close as she could get in a public setting to calling out Cliché's total lack of understanding when it came to meta-suits.

Lowering her voice, Cliché leaned in, speaking directly to Hephaestus. "Look, my friends are down there, giving everything they can to keep us safe. It's time for me to stop being so afraid of my power and see if it can do something of value, like helping stop that jerk. From behind the scenes, though, ideally."

"Lovely as the sentiment is, that doesn't change the fact that you have no idea how to work on this equipment." Hephaestus was half-scared, half-curious on where this was leading. Knowing the ability Cliché possessed, it could truly be anything.

"Not at the moment, sure, but you're forgetting one important fact: **Anything you can do, I can do better.**"

It was the first time Hephaestus had seen an immediate physical shift accompany Cliché's empowered words—even the aesthetic change had been slightly delayed. This time, it was a bizarre experience as Hephaestus

watched a familiar pair of eyes suddenly look back at her from Chloe's sockets. She knew them in an instant, and had there not been a helmet between them, the same eyes would have been staring right back at Chloe. They were, after all, the eyes of Tori Rivas.

For a moment, the stolen irises stared back, until they began to dissolve like shimmering flames, drawing into Cliché's pupil, revealing her own eyes once more. Suddenly, she grabbed the sides of her head, wincing in visible pain as her whole body began to shake.

"Gaaaah, okay, okay, I think I'm—crrraaaaap." She swayed, and for a moment, Hephaestus feared her friend would collapse entirely. "Hang on. Little longer. I think... nearly there." At last, her eyes opened, tears streaming down her face. "Wow. That was like an ice-cream headache multiplied by a root canal. So *much* getting crammed in at once. I think this one might be tougher depending on how much power I'm copying." Shaking off the last of her brain pain, Cliché's gaze fell upon the removed gauntlet. "Oh, hey, looks like you misaligned one of the connectors. That's going to make this feel sluggish when you need full dexterity."

It took a tremendous amount of self-control not to bristle at that, remembering that her saying had purposefully called out being better than the subject from whom the talents were taken. Part of her wondered how that would have worked if she'd targeted the smoking bone-man instead. Given the painful reaction for just Hephaestus, it was probably best she hadn't tested the power on someone that powerful. Even if it worked, publicly using such an ability would mean Cliché would definitely no longer be under anyone's radar—not if she had a power that allowed her suddenly jump entire leagues in terms of danger.

"Glad to know, but let's focus on getting this thing capable of handling Plasmodia's output. Efficiency is more of a refining concern than an immediate worry."

From below, there tore a scream. This wasn't like the muffled thuds of bodies and blows being thrown. Someone had just been hurt, and based on the voice, that person was Agent Quantum. Presto, Hat Trick, and even their pseudo-prisoner were all staring with rapt attention through the hole. Plasmodia, however, was striding over to join them.

"What happened?" Cliché asked.

"He forced them to make a guess, and it went poorly." Plasmodia sat down, crossing her legs like she was settling in for a session of yoga. "You

two keep working. I'm going to work on building up my energy. If we're betting it all on one shot, then I'm going to put every last bit of intensity I have into the attack." The crackling glow of power radiated up from her hands, stretching across her entire body inch by inch.

The message was clear: if they wanted to save everyone, time was running out. Once the smoking stranger was no longer amused by playing with his toys, he'd begin breaking them. On a small, muted video still playing in a corner of her helmet screen, Fornax was giving a live demonstration of exactly what happened when a real monster grew bored. Unless they wanted one of their own to end up like Zerle Salvryn, they had to change the situation.

Activating the soldering torch in the finger of her right gauntlet, Hephaestus cracked into her creation and got to work.



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## Chapter 117

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The scream had belonged to Agent Quantum. As he went in next to Medley, the two of them attempting to knock their enemy off-balance, the opponent suddenly shifted in ferocity. One hand shot out, slamming into Medley's torso and sending him through a wall, shattering a bathtub. Agent Quantum wasn't so lucky as he found his own blow caught, the arm being squeezed so hard it drove him to his knees in moments.

"That's enough pondering. Time for you to make a guess. Any takers, or should I move right on to the penalty for failure?" As their opponent raised his smoking, gaunt hand, no one knew exactly what the punishment would be, but they could all make educated guesses that it would hurt.

Agent Quantum twisted his head, meeting what technically qualified as the man's eyes. "How about Mr. Bones?" Although the name was patently ridiculous, Agent Quantum had heard stranger. Besides, he didn't expect to be right. If the name were really guessable, the offer never would have been put forth.

"Thematic, yet incorrect." The man's eyes darted over to where Bahamut was slowly shaking off the last round of attacks, and to the shifting debris of a bathroom covering Medley. "Now we move on to the fun part of the game. Tell me, Agent Quantum, who shall be punished for this failure? It can be you, another cape, or even one of these villains you've formed a shaky alliance with."

"Your problem is with me. Leave them out of it."

Not quite a laugh, not quite a cackle, the hideous amusement that brimmed from that lipless mouth was almost as terrifying as the threats.

“Exactly the answer I would expect from a superhero of your caliber. But the first one is easy. Let’s see how noble you remain after understanding what you’re in for.”

His movement was sudden, smoking right hand extended so the bony fingertips were pointed forward, then thrust into the meat of Agent Quantum’s left shoulder. The scream was immediate, like it had been pushed out by force of the blow. It wasn’t merely pain, though; everyone in the room had taken enough injuries to understand what that looked like. Agent Quantum was leaned over, barely hanging on as his whole body twitched and seized. Finally, the man yanked his hand free, leaving Agent Quantum collapsed on the ground. He didn’t stay there long, stirring soon, but the point was made.

“As your friend warned you, I am your weakness. That doesn’t just mean my ability lessens yours, ironically enough, but also that it hurts tremendously in the process. Now then, once you’re able to speak, let’s hear your next guess. I hope it’s better—”

The speech trailed off as the form of Tachyonic suddenly dove through the hole in the ceiling, landing roughly on the bed then scrambling off of it. Standing at a visible lean, there was no pretending he was able to fight at full strength, but he *was* standing. Given the state of his leg minutes before, that in itself was impressive enough.

“Perfect. It’s so much more enjoyable when someone personally invested has to watch. A coworker and a temporary ally aren’t the same as being taken apart in front of someone who believes in you.” The man’s eyes lingered on Agent Quantum, despite him making no forward movements. Now that the game was in full swing, he was enjoying himself far too much to rush it. The Wrexwren weren’t even dealt with yet, and once they were, the chaos would last for hours. Plenty of time to savor his triumph.

At last, Bahamut was back up, visibly groggy yet upright nonetheless. From the bathroom, Medley’s tail broke through, sweeping off shards of porcelain as he rose. Agent Quantum had made it to a turned-over chair and was using that to haul himself up. Just like when Tachyonic has been stabbed by those digits, Agent Quantum was visibly weakened, more than what just pain could manage.

Wobbling forward, not fully trusting his own leg yet, Tachyonic held up his hands and made a “come get some” motion. “Hey asshole, how about Round Two? Only this time, no sucker punch.”

“Do you know why it is prudent to take out the team’s speeder first? It isn’t because they’re dangerous—few ever manage to do significant damage against real threats. Your kind are simply annoying, dashing about in the middle of a fight. And *you* especially have a talent for failure. Being my hostage was perhaps the closest you’ve come to doing something right.”

The man turned away, facing Agent Quantum once more. “You are beneath me, Tachyonic, as are the rest of this silly ensemble. But you aren’t even entertaining enough to break. Stay patient. You’ll die when I get around to it.”

The wet *smack* was not the blow the smoking man, or anyone else, was expecting. Tachyonic became a momentary blur as he ran to the kitchen’s garbage can, yanked out a semi-full bag, and slapped it over his opponent’s head. No one was entirely sure what the owner of this kitchen had made the night prior, only that it was very sauce-heavy. Unidentifiable green and red liquids dripped down the lengths of the near-skeleton, whose smoke suddenly increased in amount and darkness.

“You dare—”

“You’re goddamn right I dare!” Tachyonic was right there, in his face, so aggressive it seemed to knock their opponent momentarily off-balance. “Where do you get off, strutting around like the big shit in town? Do you know why your little game works? Because none of us know who the fuck you are! All these big claims about fighting the original Science Sentries—except we’ve gone through all of their old cases and fights as part of our training. If you really were around, then you left so little impression it didn’t even warrant mentioning.”

In a flash of movement, Tachyonic dashed back several feet, wincing at the end as his leg nearly gave out. Ignoring the pain, he repeated his previous hand-motion, once more inviting their opponent to trade blows. “You’re a nobody. Nothing but forgotten trash. You don’t *deserve* to face Agent Quantum yet. Team leaders are reserved for actual threats, the kinds with real reputations, not sad fantasies they’ve concocted.”

In terms of subtlety, there was a lot of room for improvement. Tachyonic might as well have been waving a red flag and wearing a matador’s outfit. That was the upside to blunt attacks, though: they didn’t have to be refined to be effective.

Plumes of dark smoke rose from the man, searing off all the garbage on his person into a sizzling residue that clung to the floor where it landed. He

stared at Tachyonic, all others momentarily forgotten.

“Such a dear, devoted friend you are, taking my wrath all for yourself. Very well, Tachyonic, I’ll grant your wish. My statement holds true: you aren’t worth the entertainment. Yet I think it will be rather enjoyable to watch Agent Quantum’s face as I tear his most devoted supporter limb from limb.”



In spite of being less an arm and down a leg, Zerle Salvrin refused to buckle. His assaults continued, their techniques changing on the fly. The Zerle even scored a few hits with unexpected movements, making use of the now missing appendage’s space. Fornax let him come, parrying here, knocking back there, but otherwise keeping him at bay and suffering. There was a next step to this process; however, it couldn’t be initiated by Fornax. Moving forward had to begin with Lodestar or Zerle Salvrin himself.

As it turned out, the latter arrived first. After taking a rough punch to where his hips would be on a human, the Wrexwren leader did not immediately attempt to spring back up. Instead, he sat, leaning his head and back against the cool metal of the chamber’s walls.

“My pride as a fighter can deny it no longer. You are indeed stronger than I, Fornax.” Zerle Salvrin made a motion with his hand, though what it was or what it meant, Fornax could only speculate. Perhaps a gesture of respect?

“Is this your way of calling it quits? I must say, I didn’t see that coming from you.” He paused, rune-filled eyes sweeping across the alien enemy. “Still don’t, actually.”

“Nor should you. I will never admit defeat, nor permit you to take victory.” Zerle Salvrin made the noise Fornax felt reasonably sure was laughter, albeit low and subdued. “My people saw the command given. As we speak, they are already training their weapons on this ship. We will be annihilated together, along with the entirety of the crew, but you will not triumph today.” Having taken a breather, the Wrexwren got up, keeping weight off his broken leg. “I hope now you understand the Wrexwren people’s commitment to victory. Not even our own leaders are of greater importance.”

The whistle was sharp and high, nearly a Wrexwren voice, except it came from Fornax's puckered lips. "Hell of a move. Rather die than lose. Believe it or not, I get that. Even respect it, in the right circumstances. Of course, I could always kill you before the attack hits."

"Which is why I took my time explaining. It's already too late. The blast will arrive at any moment." Zerle Salvrin raised his remaining arms, determined to hold out until mutual destruction took them both.

Fornax made no move to follow up on his threat, turning his attention to the floating cameras instead.

"Well then, it seems our only recourse is to patiently wait for the end to come. In these, my final moments of life, I would like to leave all of you viewers with a simple bit of advice: never start a war with the most dangerous species in the galaxy."

With that, Fornax turned, facing Zerle Salvrin as they waited for the ship to explode. After ten seconds, Zerle Salvrin began to get worried. After a full minute, true terror set in. Finally, he broke, the question bursting forth as he watched the absolute lack of concern remain in Fornax's grin. "What have you done?"

"Me? I've been in here with you, having a grand old time. But I'm not the only villain out there with stress to relieve. In fact, while we were playing around, my old friend Doctor Mechaniacal was working on his own project. Doc, you want to take it away?"

From all around them, broadcast over the Wrexwren's own communications system, the answer came. "Gladly. After some basic analysis, I discovered quite a number of weaknesses in the design and programming used in your ships. Redundancy is all well and good; however, the trouble with using identical components over and over is that they all have the same vulnerabilities. For example, did you know it was possible to create an overload sequence in the engines, leading to catastrophic detonation? Ten seconds, and any Wrexwren ship is nothing more than debris in the void."

"An entire ship... you wouldn't. There is no honor in such a tactic."

Fornax laughed at that, loud and cruel. "You don't get to say shit about honor. Tricking Earth's champion, launching the invasion before our duel, even trying to cheat at the last minute when losing became inevitable. You have held to whatever code the Wrexwren have in only the most technical sense. I will say this much, though: you're right. We *wouldn't* do that."

The smile widened as new images flashed into existence all around; Doctor Mechaniacal was really getting the hang of the Wrexwren systems. The entire invasion fleet still in space, from the largest warship to the tiniest landing vessel, were being detonated before Zerle Salvrin's eyes, the scenes played over and over on a constant, repeating loop.

"We wouldn't, because we already did." Fornax spread his arms, gesturing to the cornucopia of destruction surrounding them. "What sort of creature would do a thing like that? Kill an entire army when peace is still on the table? What sort of species would even conceive of such a notion, wiping out their enemy without prudence or partiality? It's the same one that fell upon your people the moment they landed. A species born in war and conflict, with millennia to hone both their skill and the darkest parts of their souls. You would shrivel in disgust to know what we have done to each other, for crimes no greater than a hue of skin or a place of birth. What did you think would be waiting for monstrous invaders such as yourselves?"

He faced the floating cameras once more, and for the first time, Zerle Salvrin began to understand that this wasn't really about him at all. Whoever was on the other side of those orbs, that was the target Fornax was trying to reach. Ordinarily, he'd have considered that useful information for controlling the tide of the fight. As it was, Zerle Salvrin was momentarily lost in the horror of seeing his entire force purged so completely. Much as he wanted to think it all a trick, the fact that they were still here meant the other ships had failed to fire. Zerle Salvrin's life was proof of his people's death.

"My advice earlier was genuine," Fornax continued, speaking directly into the cameras. "It is indeed prudent not to start a war with the galaxy's most dangerous species. Only, the Wrexwren are not the holders of that title. They are a simple, brute force: effective at their own tasks, yet inherently limited by their own rules. No, the true danger would be creatures capable of planning, deception, and untold death, all without a moment's pause. An imagination that can conceive of terrible ideas, the sort no decent species would ever consider, let alone put into use. Beings who can justify any atrocity, so long as they come out on top."

Pointing back over his shoulder, Fornax drew attention to the array of exploding images all around him and Zerle Salvrin. "Meet humanity: the most twisted, murderous, foul species in the entire cosmos. We are the ones

you should have avoided conflict with. Now, you get to be a warning for the rest of the galaxy, a tale to tell over whatever the alien versions of campfires are. The once mighty Wrexwren, destroyed by one simple, poor decision: they decided to fuck with Earth.”

Finally managing to gather some of his thoughts, Zerle Salvryn glared back defiantly. “Do not think one kolitre is the entirety of the Wrexwren force. There will be more to follow, to avenge our failing.”

“My dear Zerle, don’t be so impatient. We’ll get to that, when the time is right. A being like you, possessing such willpower and strength, must be broken properly.” Fornax started forward, a fresh look of excitement in his rune-filled eyes. “Have no fear, you are in the hands of a professional. I will make sure to see the job done *right*.”

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## Chapter 118

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This world was a hellscape. Humans were not the docile, simple creatures that had been painted for the Wrexwren forces. They fought like prexles, a notoriously ferocious pest on the Wrexwren home world, famous for its willingness to lash out when dying rather than flee. Prexles would prefer to wound their enemy in death than to survive, and somehow, it felt like humanity had stolen that philosophy from across the stars.

Even the ones that lacked abilities were armed, opening fire on the trio of Wrexwren as they ran through the streets, fleeing their pursuers. The ship was lost, blown up minutes after landing. The team's only hope was to find somewhere to hunker down and call for rescue. Not that they felt great about the odds, given how many similar cries for help were pinging their own systems. With every passing step, the effort of running became more and more futile.

Just when a few of the Wrexwren were pondering the prexle route themselves, something strange happened. The team was advancing on a dilapidated old building with dozens of vehicles in front of it, and as they drew closer, their pursuers started to fall away. Together, the aliens ran faster, and saw the trend continued. No explanation to be had; perhaps this ground was somehow cursed or sacred to the native species. After a day full of the worst sorts of surprises, none of the three was willing to argue with a turn of good fortune. Together, they raced up to the front and burst through the door.

For a moment, the first Wrexwren thought it was some sort of human design choice. Red splashes all over the floors and walls, bits and chunks



spread around to create a messy ambience. It was a forgivable initial mistake; they were hardly familiar with much human anatomy. Upon spotting an arm, however, the Wrexwren reassessed the situation, along with estimating roughly how many humans would be required to create this much debris.

“What happened?” The whisper came from one of the others, communicated in the softest of their whistles as possible.

“Somebody didn’t live up to the hype.” This response came from deeper in the building, and while they had translation software equipped, it was unneeded. Whoever the mysterious being was, they’d replied in the native Wrexwren tongue. Footsteps rang out from further in the building, unseen in the thin strips of light streaming through from outer streetlamps. Darkness was in swing on this section of the planet, though all of the aliens suddenly wished they had a bit of sunshine on their side.

Raising their weapons, too aware that this might be a chance where they only got a single shot, the Wrexwren at the front called out. “Who goes there?”

“This was a meta-mercenary base. True war might be banned, but countries still have conflict, and this team was often hired to fill a given side’s ranks. They were quite renowned, especially their leader: a man wielding a magical sword, said to be one of the most skilled fighters on the planet.”

From the shadows an object came, tossed much too short to come within striking distance of the team, yet they all tensed just the same. It landed with a clatter—or rather, they landed. It turned out to be two objects which had once been whole. A golden sword, sparks of fading power crackling along the edges, sliced cleanly in two.

“I waited so patiently for a chance to strike in secret, a time when the blame could be put elsewhere, like an invading force. Such pains making sure not to lose Captain Bullshit’s veil, only for this absolute disappointment to be my reward. Not a good day. Not a good day at all.”

A spray of sparks came from the darkness, metal being run along concrete. For the first time, the aliens saw who they’d been speaking with. He appeared human, save for the twisted expression on his face. Mundane clothes, no visible armor, equipped with a single weapon: another sword, this one with a slight curve to the blade. The Wrexwren weren’t especially

familiar with the names of Earth's out-of-date weaponry, but there was enough context to expect it would be dangerous.

"I know you won't be any better. I do. But after waiting this long for such a worthless taste, I can't be satisfied with just this." The sparks ended, and suddenly, the man was in front of the first Wrexwren. His blade moved a single time, and the would-be invader felt his upper body sliding, leaving the lower portion behind. There was just enough mental function to hear his next words in the alien's final moments.

"After so long trapped in its sheath, my sword *thirsts*."



Grantham was mildly surprised by the small army waiting outside the bar. They were not made of Wrexwren—in fact, everyone present was either human or meta. Sipping his beer, he bristled at the chill hitting his lips. Damnit, he'd held the glass for too long.

"Diego, what's the deal with the battalion?"

His bartender, a svelte man with dangerous tattoos running up and down both arms, jumped slightly at being directly addressed. Thus far, he'd been one of the only people Grantham had bothered to learn the name of and occasionally talk to, largely because Diego also spoke English. Neither Diego nor the others were sure if that made him safer, or more in peril. All they knew for certain was that this was not a child to cross.

"They are from a neighboring compound and seek to lay claim on our holdings, attacking during the confusion. Word has probably spread about the prior owners being slaughtered."

"Yet nobody thinks to wonder if the thing that did the slaughtering is still around." Spinning on his stool, for a brief moment, it was possible to forget the absolute power this kid had used to rule them with since arriving; he looked like any other normal child. The effect ended as soon as he stopped, and Diego could see the icy-blue shining in his eyes. "What the hell—I could use a workout, and I doubt this will count as making a scene."

As his feet touched the ground, his skin changed, turning the blue of one lost and frozen in the deepest tundra. Muscle bulged in his limbs as his height shot up, reaching and passing that of an adult's stature in no time. A bushy beard of frost sprouted on his no longer childish face. He was out of

the bar before fully transforming, largely because the door couldn't accommodate his modified bulk.

From outside, the deeper, older voice thundered. "Look at this pathetic lot! Such a pitiful offering. Your bodies will serve as warning to those who come next. Only the strong can face Jokull!"



Groggily, the lone surviving Wrexwren struggled back to consciousness. He'd been with a team of four. One had been killed on landing, forcing them to flee. The forest had seemed like a good place for cover, until they reached a patch where the ground gave way. Between the fall and the blunted stone triangles at the bottom, the others died on impact. Only a bit of fortune had influenced the survivor's fall, shattering a pair of legs and one arm rather than his head. It was a curious choice for a trap—sharp objects at the bottom would have a much higher lethal success rate.

Overhead, something new came into view. It appeared to be one of Earth's native species, called a bear, except the alien felt almost positive bears didn't have horns, or opposable thumbs on a huge, hairy hand. Most of the creature was off in some way, yet it moved with certainty as it grabbed the living Wrexwren and began to drag the captive along.

For a while, the ground was dirt, then slowly stones started showing up. Tighter and tighter they grew, until it was as if they were on some stone-cobbled path. Strange as that was, it had nothing on the door they reached: huge, dense, and a striking shade of white that stood out amidst the darkness of the subterranean lair. The bear-like creature knocked once, and instantly, the door gave way.

Inside was a room lit by electric lanterns. White shelves lined the walls, decorated with various knickknacks and pops of color. Chairs in the same white hue were lined up next to a matching table, not far from an actual bed. To the sides of the room, tunnels were visible, some smaller than what a human could fit through, others too large even for bear-sized creatures. Seated on a pillow in the center, preparing herself a cup of liquid from some sort of white cup-and-jug set, was what appeared to be a human woman.

She wore a lavender dress, barely fitting over her visibly emaciated frame. Frail, thin, he could see her bones moving through the skin as she

reached for her cup and took a tentative sip, letting out a sharp squeak.

“It’s hot,” she said by way of explanation, the Wrexwren’s translator conveying the general meeting. “I suppose we should start with an apology. I’m afraid you’re going to find me a terrible host today.”

Bad as this was, perhaps all hadn’t yet been lost. If she was the meta controlling this beast, then killing her could set it free. That would put him alone with a wild animal, but that was still a better fight than having it puppeteered by someone with intelligence.

“I wish I could offer you some wonderful options to replace what you’ve broken. Unfortunately, laying low means I haven’t been able to collect any human or meta parts. All my lovie’s have come from the nearby forest.”

At her words, new sounds came from within the tunnels. Few approached the flickering light of the electric lanterns; however, there were enough misshapen shadows to know that none of these creatures were currently in the same configuration as they’d been born.

“Even that might not be so bad, except Sissy doesn’t like to help me build anymore. I can’t do nearly as clean of work without her. Modern medicine helps bridge the gap, but her ability made things so much more stable. And *far* less messy.”

Deciding that this was his only shot, the Wrexwren slammed his remaining three arms into the ground, shooting up and kicking off with his pair of working legs. The effort was successful, in that he managed to get clear of the bear-monster’s reach. That was the end of the positive outcome, and the Wrexwren’s advancement, however.

From the table and each chair came a spear, molding from their very material, firing out and piercing directly into the Wrexwren’s flesh. Four lances where the dining area had been, skewering him in place, lifting up slightly so he was unable to even use the ground for traction.

“While I did say I was going to be a terrible host, I can’t believe I forget to introduce myself. My friends call me Cathy, but I guess you’d probably be more interested in my professional title. Before I got locked away and had my old lovie’s taken, people used to call me the Bone Mage.”

The shadows were slinking out from the tunnel, a menagerie of warped creations, each spliced together in a hideous hodgepodge. From her pillow, Cathy rose as well, stepping lightly over to take a closer look at her newly captured specimen. When she reached out, the Wrexwren tried to jerk its

head back. That earned him a gentle smile, as well as a hand delicately running along his torso.

“There’s no need to fear. I’m going to take good care of you, or as much of you as I can. Alien physiology is tricky. Luckily, I’ve got the rest of your friends to experiment on first. Don’t worry. I’ll get all the mistakes out before it’s your turn. We’ll make you stronger than you ever were before. Relax, be at peace, and look forward to what the future holds.”

That gentle smile sharpened, and her wide eyes shined down like mad moons, like they couldn’t wait to unveil the horrors laying in store. “I just *know* you’re going to enjoy being one of my lovies.”



Clad in a scat-brown suit and bowler hat, no one would mistake this man as an icon of fashion... not that the gentleman clad in such an ensemble gave even the smallest of notions to the opinions of the masses on any topic, including clothes. Compliance with the herd was a practice for the weak. Those with power lived in whatever way suited them best. This was simply one more way he marked himself as above them. Although, not quite so far above them as the woman currently on screen.

Unlike the rest of the world, he had no interest in watching Fornax piss about—the man had been insufferable enough when they shared a prison together. Trying to view Lodestar with magic was a fool’s errand, so they’d simply found the Wrexwren broadcast and tuned in to that with the help of a peon. Other metas often looked down on those with powers focused more toward utility than combat, while those of wisdom knew it was always handy to keep such talents around.

“Worried she might not win?” This man wore simple garments with a high collar—almost a priest’s outfit, yet not quite.

“For a meta who uses the name ‘Faithful,’ you certainly express a great deal of doubt.” In truth, he knew why Faithful wore such a moniker, and the history that made it such a hideous joke. One did not align with Faithful unless there was good reason, and it was *never* wise to fully trust him. Yet Faithful’s power was so great, sometimes the risk was worth it to gain access to his abilities.

With a completely sincere expression, Faithful lowered his head in apology. “Consider me chastised. Against such a tremendous threat, I thought perhaps even the Lodestar might have some trouble.”

“A Lodestar, certainly, but not *that* Lodestar. She’s already ascended to greater heights than this. If she were dispatched by such a base, rudimentary threat, she wouldn’t be the prize worth pursuing.”

The bowler hat tipped back, revealing a face worn by the years, unlike Faithful, who remained young and spry no matter how much time piled up on top of him. “My mistake the first time was moving too fast. This is no ordinary cape to bring low; it was folly to think of her that way. One does not snare an apex predator the same way they catch meager prey. This will be a long hunt. Keep that in mind if you get any urges to make a spectacle and lose yourself Captain Bullshit’s veil.”

“My urges are entirely in check, until they aren’t,” Faithful replied, as if that settled the matter. “I’m more curious on how, precisely, you expect to snare her. Not even my ability was able to overcome that cape, and I was among the most offensively powerful in Rookstone.”

The bowler hat dipped down as its owner nodded in agreement. “The trouble was that you came at her head-on, as did I, as did almost everyone else. We all forgot a truth as simple as a nursery lullaby.” He hummed a few bars to himself, watching as Lodestar grew brighter, hitting her opponent over and over to no effect.

“If you seek to catch a star, first you have to make it fall.”

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## Chapter 119

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This enemy should be beyond her. Lodestar understood that, as another attempt to even dissuade it from the current course failed to draw so much as a reaction. It existed on a scale beyond what humans were designed to fathom, let alone challenge. To stand against the Scralthor was like seeking to halt a sun's meltdown mid-nova. These were not forces they were meant to have control over. And yet, for better or worse, she was permitted to break that limit. Human-shaped wasn't the same as human.

For even another Lodestar, this creature likely represented a final task. Tapping that deeply into the power would be enough to wipe out any trace of the person wielding it, all but guaranteeing that someone else would be burdened with the mantle. Under normal circumstances, this would be her last bout: going out in a final blaze of glory to keep her planet safe.

Except that Helen had a secret that not even most of the other capes knew. Over a decade before, she'd floated in the depths of space, squaring off against another seemingly unbeatable opponent: Orion. With his speed, power, and semi-intangible nature, even her abilities hadn't been enough to fully stop the former scientist bent on destroying the world. At least, not at first. Not until the fight neared its climax, and she finally understood her place in the cosmos.

Not until she broke the rules.

"You're just hungry." She said it to no one but the vast monster. Even the Wrexwren ships that had been leading the Scralthor were gone now, blown up with all the others—no doubt the guild was somehow responsible. "This isn't your fault, and I get that. Someone is using you. This was never

a fight you wanted any part of. As much as I can, I'll try to hold back. With what I'm about to do, there are no promises."

She blasted off, soaring into space, tightening her focus as she moved. It was easier to access while active, gave her somewhere to channel the excess energy as it was building. Distance traveled didn't matter. By the time she was ready, it would largely be a question of how fast she chose to move. Still, she had to be focused. This was only her second occasion going past the current limit.

Last time, there had only been the absolute injustice of the situation to focus on, and her own unwillingness to bend to it. That was the night she learned that roles were just words, and that even a Lodestar could be greedy. Today was different. She could already feel that as the heightened levels of power flowed into her, trying to drown out the woman at their center.

Between the daughter, friends, and history on that planet, there was no chance she was letting the Scralthor plunge it into darkness. Scorching through the void, Lodestar wasn't just glowing anymore. She'd begun to shine.



Cyber Geek and Cold Shoulder arrived back at the hole just in time to catch the end of their mystery attacker's threat toward Tachyonic. He wasn't making empty overtures, either—those bony hands came grabbing for Tachyonic immediately. Luckily, he was still mobile enough to dodge, albeit poorly. He wasn't as sluggish, though whether that was from the staff or the fact that the power-weakening attack had begun to fade was up in the air.

"What's going on?" Cyber Geek asked as Tachyonic scrambled away from the claw-like hands.

"Mystery asshole says he's going to kill everyone unless we guess his name, then probably kill everyone anyway." Hephaestus didn't look up from the glove she and Cliché were hunched over, the pair working in near perfect tandem. "Unless you have something more powerful than me and Plasmodia blasting at once, save the ammo. Delay and holding tactics would be greatly appreciated."



To their surprise, it was Cold Shoulder who perked up. “Looks like that’s me.” She started for the hole, but Presto suddenly appeared in front of her.

“Shoot from up here. He’s strong enough that he can kill any of us with one hit. Ice-armor isn’t likely to change that, and I don’t think he’s going to react well if you actually do hinder him.”

Cold Shoulder hesitated, until Plasmodia jumped in, still seated and building her charge. “Presto doesn’t joke around when we’re losing, and he’s actually got a good head on his shoulders. That guy is toying with them. Let’s not give him any more targets, especially less durable ones.”

That evidently convinced her, as she perched at the edge and watched the battle unfold, swirls of frost dancing in her hands as she waited for the opportunity to strike. Plasmodia and Presto were by her side, neither of them paying proper attention to the green trespasser in their care, who was mostly poking her head over to watch the same show play out.

Meanwhile, Cyber Geek was hung up on the rest of the conundrum, trying to guess the attacker’s name. There were so many games where avatar names popped up automatically, and he knew that some interface components came over when he used head-covering items from specific games. Unfortunately, so far, none had name-revealing properties; otherwise, he’d have known who was really under Hephaestus’s mask. This was where he needed more item variety, the kinds of situations where his power could truly excel, if only he knew the right option to use.

“Do we have any clues on mystery man?” Cyber Geek wasn’t expecting much, but knowing he was too weak to fight directly and apparently not powerful enough to fire an effective shot, this was all he could think of to do.

“Well, he looks like that, so there’s a starting point,” Presto noted. “Says he fought the original Science Sentries, seems to really hate Professor Quantum, basically untouchable in terms of strength, and his power directly weakens those with abilities derived from setlium exposure. That’s all we know.”

Plasmodia’s head popped up as something occurred to her. “And it’s ironic that he has that effect on setlium—at least to him. I’m ninety percent sure he said that.”

Tachyonic’s voice came over the communicators, a sharp reminder they were still broadcasting locally, words spit fast between pants for air. “He

also claimed to know Professor Quantum before the change. Said he was the first destroyed by the professor's ambition."

Who could have lived that long and still remained unknown? For that matter, why would it be anything other than pure convenience to have an ability that neutralized not only one of the most legendary capes in existence, but also hindered everyone sharing the same source of powers? A sudden notion scratched at Cyber Geek's mind, intuition cobbling together the pieces he was too frantic to see. There was one thread of an idea firm enough to pull on, so that's what he did, yanking out his AHC phone and opening up a quick tab for research. It certainly didn't feel heroic, skimming the internet as his friends were fighting for their lives, but Cyber Geek was fast learning not to give a shit about what did and didn't feel like cape-work.

If it had even a chance of keeping someone alive, then it was time well spent. Besides, this didn't have the feeling of a wild goose chase. Cyber Geek was on to something. The question was if he'd figure it out in time to matter.



The dodges were working, at a cost. Between the injured ankle and the residual effects of being weakened, it was taking everything Tachyonic had to avoid the clawed blows. From behind, Medley ran up on their attacker, throwing the entirety of his bulk into one of the bony man's joints. It was truly the only technique he'd managed with any effectiveness, knocking his opponent briefly off-balance before a smoking leg kicked Medley across the room and into a wall.

If not for incredible endurance and rapid healing, Medley and Bahamut would both be out of the fight already, likely in shape similar to Agent Quantum. Tachyonic felt pangs of guilt as he backpedaled, equally aware of what these distractions were costing them, and how badly they were needed. Without those two drawing occasional focus so he could rest, the dance would already be over.

Sadly, there weren't many steps left to it either way. Tachyonic zipped around, grabbing a meat tenderizer from the kitchen. He tried to break it over the man's skull, hoping to annoy more than hurt at this point, keeping

focus away from Agent Quantum. As he made the approach, Tachyonic's ankle hit a poor position and suddenly buckled. Not enough to send him sprawling, though that was largely because of the strong, gaunt, smoking hands that grabbed onto Tachyonic before he could land.

"At last, my little fly, you've wandered too close. Let's see what we can do about pulling off those wings."

"Rob Bob." The name was nonsense to Tachyonic, as well as everyone else in the room based on their expressions, yet Agent Quantum didn't pause before throwing out another. "Todd Williams. William Todds. Jack Crack. Is that enough guesses for a penalty yet?"

Injured or not, Agent Quantum was on his feet, dragging himself to a standing position thanks to the wall. "That's the game, right? Guess and take the penalties. Well I just earned myself four, and they're all coming to me. Unless you'd rather play with Tachyonic than finish trying to break me."

For a face lacking flesh, the stranger did an excellent job of showing his momentary indecision. "You are already beaten."

"If this was about crushing me, you could have done that on a street corner in the middle of the night. Whatever you're after, I don't think it's just proving you can take us in a fight, and I'm positive it has nothing to do with my friend. You want to hurt Professor Quantum, right? I'm the one walking around wearing part of his name and using some of his DNA. I'm the one you want to hurt."

Medley and Bahamut, both slowly having shaken off their last blows, were nearby, watching the act play out silently, unwilling to move and risk tipping whatever gambit was in play. If either was surprised by the revelation of Agent Quantum's origins, they had more important matters at the forefront of their minds.

"Yes, you are," the man agreed. "But unlike Professor Quantum, it seems you truly care for your team. And there are many ways to hurt someone."

"Maybe so, but you challenged me to take the pain until I caved and gave it to someone else. Maim Tachyonic, and it's the same as admitting you couldn't defeat me. Not the way you wanted to."

For a delicate moment, no one moved, all of them too aware that this man could squash Tachyonic's head in a single motion if he so chose. Finally, the dark skull turned back to its captive. "I suppose it would be

disappointing, to come all this way and not see you ultimately turn on those who trust you. Though I've had enough of this pest flitting around."

The sharp tips of his left hand broke the skin on Tachyonic's arm, and he stabbed his right fingers into the thigh on the cape's non-injured leg—a short combo that drew a brief yelp of pain before Tachyonic collapsed. Between the new injuries and the power-weakening effects, he'd done his last running of the battle. Their enemy stepped over Tachyonic's writhing form, shifting toward Agent Quantum.

"Now then, about those penalties."

Before the man was fully turned, Medley sprang, launching at their enemy's head. Between the fur, bulk, and general confusion, he was able to hang on long enough to hammer home a few blows before getting roughly hurled through a wooden beam. Loud creaks came from overhead, as Medley dimly realized how many of the support structures on this floor had been already taken out.

Futile as the attack seemed, it gave Bahamut enough time to run in and drag Tachyonic away. She even managed to return as Medley was getting thrown, grabbing a chunk of broken granite from what had once been a kitchen counter and smashing it against the bone man's back. He spun around, surprisingly quick when he wanted to be, and snared one of her arms. That was all it took, so great was the strength difference between them. For the first time since she'd been transformed into a dragon against her will, Bahamut was truly feeling the limits of her power, and it was not an experience she had any interest in repeating.

Dragging her along, the man looked back to Agent Quantum. "What about this one? Are you also willing to suffer in place of a villain? Who knows the number of innocents these claws and teeth have drawn blood from, how many injustices they've perpetrated. You're a superhero; surely it serves the greater good for me to hobble criminals and leave you at full strength."

"There's nothing good about passing my problems on to someone else, greater or otherwise. Maybe he deserves what you'd give, but if I bought into that philosophy, I'd never have become a superhero in the first place. We're not here to punish. We're here to protect. Now, are you done wasting time with these distractions? I'm half-recovered from that last attack; you'd better get moving if you want to stand a chance."

A plainly empty bluff, yet Bahamut was still released from the iron grip, all interest from her captor instantly lost. “You put on a better show than he did, I’ll give you that. Which will make it all the more enjoyable as I rip that façade of nobility away and show them all who you truly are.”

In an unexpected bound, the man crossed the gap between him and Agent Quantum, easily snaring the weakened cape by the back of his neck and holding him roughly in place. “Which brings us to your punishments. Can’t take your tongue yet—I’ll need to hear you talk so you can cave—and most of the senses will be vital in watching your own body torn apart. A limb might be a good start, though I do worry you may bleed out too soon.”

The sharp fingers traced along Agent Quantum’s face, leaving a red abrasion wherever they ran, until stopping on the bridge of his nose. “Then again, I suppose you could still see your team butchered with only one eye. The real question is, which one to take? I have just the solution, one that Professor Quantum would find great appreciation in.” His finger began to tap under each eye in succession as he spoke. “Eenie... meenie... miney...”  
“Alfred!”

What should have been a random name being shouted in desperation instead had a very curious effect. Their attacker halted, finger still halfway between eyes for the next tap, all attention shifting to the hole above, where Cyber Geek’s head was poking through.

“That’s who you are. Alfred Settler, the member of Professor Quantum’s team supposedly killed in the experiment that created meta-humans. You’re the man setlium was named after.”

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## Chapter 120

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Laughter. That was the bone man—or rather, Alfred’s—response. Tittering chuckles that oozed from his mouth as he looked from Agent Quantum, still held tightly in his grip, to the virtually unknown cape that had awkwardly blundered into such a revelation. Unfortunately, this was not the kind of mirth that signaled a positive shift in mood. If anything, he appeared even more dangerous.

“Alfred Settler is supposed to be dead,” Agent Quantum said from his prone position, searching his captor’s fleshless face as though there were clues to be found. “When Professor Quantum’s experiment changed the world, most of the team with him became the first meta-humans. Alfred was killed, and Professor Quantum named what he saw as his greatest discovery in honor of their fallen team member.”

“Yes, that *is* the story.” Without warning, Alfred hurled Agent Quantum through yet another chunk of wall, drawing groans from bits of ceiling overhead. While the cape struggled to his feet, blood dripped from fresh wounds; in his weakened state, even the lesser attacks were causing damage. “Because the truth casts such a hideous light on the great, beloved Professor Quantum. I wasn’t just some assistant caught in the blast. Nearly half the work on that experiment was *mine*! *I* was the one who saw the greater potential, who warned your supposed hero that there were dangers he wasn’t considering. *I* was the lone voice of caution who stood against the experiment, and *this* is how fate repaid me.”

He gestured to himself, to the smoking skeleton with the barest bits of muscle tissue keeping it held together. “I’m sure they thought me dead. My

body had become corrosive to everything, in varying degrees, and looked like this. By the time I woke up, I was entombed in a metal box and buried under literal tons of rock, the same way we treated nuclear materials at the time. But that's the upside to being corrosion incarnate: nothing can hold you forever."

Having a receptive audience, Alfred had fallen into one of the oldest villain habits in the book: monologuing. No one dared to interrupt. This was a chance for them to catch their breath and think a few steps ahead. Had Alfred gone through guild training, he'd have been warned on the dangers of such an indulgence, especially when the fight was not yet won.

Lifting a thin hand, he pointed directly to Agent Quantum. "Yet what should await me when I emerged? A world enamored with the same selfish, irresponsible, arrogant bastard who made me this way!" The wood under his feet turned dark and cracked at the sudden flash of anger, forcing Alfred to move closer to Agent Quantum. "Whereas I am nothing more than a footnote. Even my name he warped and corrupted to serve his own goals. What a great man, to honor the colleague he killed and erased from history by naming something I never wanted to exist after me. Of course, by the time I reemerged and the humor in that became evident, it was too late for a renaming."

Another step closer, causing everyone watching to tense up. The truth was, if he made a run for Agent Quantum, they couldn't stop him. Slow him down, maybe, but there were no delusions left to dispel; everyone present knew he'd simply been taking his time and having fun. Unless they came up with something soon, the moment he got serious, they would have to face the hard choice: flee, or die fighting.

"We were across from each other, in almost exact opposite points of the room. I wonder sometimes if that's why it worked out this way. Perhaps we inadvertently freed the entire spectrum of meta-elements in that one moment and have slowly been discovering what was in Pandora's Box. He got setlium, whereas I got the opposite. This horrible, eroding energy that kills everything except the man who would welcome it. The exact opposite of what infuses your cells with their ability. I call it: vernium. What do you think?"

Agent Quantum went momentarily stiff, drawing another round of terrible chuckles from Alfred. "That was just in case any of you thought I was spinning a yarn. I am glad to be able to tell you all this, before your

end. It's been so long since I shared that story, and I think it will add to the experience of watching your friends die. If nothing else, you'll understand why I'm going to leave them as nothing more than skeletons. A message to the man I'm playing with."

"You think he'll see this as a game?" Medley demanded. It might have been telling that the one who doubted such a sentiment was a cape who'd never worked with Professor Quantum before.

"The game is what he and I have been playing for decades. This is only a single move—though an excellent one, if I do say so myself." To their surprise, Alfred started walking again, but not toward Agent Quantum. He was heading away from everyone, toward one of the holes into the hallway punched by flinging bodies. "As for games, I suppose there is a prize that is owed. Cyber Geek, you and your team are permitted to escape, assuming you are able. Because now that my secret is out, I find it's nearly time to draw things to a close."

He didn't step through the hole, as a few might have been expecting or hoping he would. Rather, he grabbed a support beam on either side, two of the few in the area left standing, holding up everything currently over their head, including the rest of the capes and villains. "Everyone in the pool. It's time to sink or swim."

A pulse of dark energy washed over the beams—the first time they'd seen him intentionally use the corrosive power. In less than a second, the thick wooden supports were nothing more than black ash. Overhead, a loud *snap* could be heard, followed by a series of groans and crackling, before a huge chunk of the ceiling—and everyone who'd been sitting on it—came crashing down.



Bloopston was pinned down. Separated from Big Swing by the sudden Wrexwren ship that had slammed down to Earth, weakened by having to run through a burning hallway, and now with four aliens drawing close to his position. The call for help had gone out minutes prior, but hope was restrained. There was so much going on right now, and a limited amount of backup to spread around.



Just as the first Wrexwren rounded the corner, face aimed right at Bloopston, something fell from the top of the building, landing directly in front of the creature. On first glance, it appeared to be a normal person. No costume, no mask, nothing to mark this man as exceptional, not until he threw a single glance backward, permitting Bloopston to get a look at his face.

No wonder there wasn't a costume: Quorum didn't wear one. His identity, much as one could call it that, was on public display. Despite the tense situation, he still sounded calm, as another Wrexwren joined the first, sounds of the other two drawing near.

"I know you have translators. This is your only chance. Surrender now, and we can attempt to protect you. The invasion has failed, your people are beaten, but as individuals there might be a path of peace for you moving forward."

In response, the first Wrexwren took a swing at Quorum, who deftly leaned out of the way before returning a blow to a spot on the left side of its chest. As the alien choked, two more hits came, striking a specific point in the torso, and one just above where two of the legs joined. Three quick strikes, and his opponent was lying on the ground, making a sound Bloopston felt reasonably sure was gasping.

Seeing its ally injured, the second alien began to raise a weapon. The attempt was leagues too slow, as Quorum had the speed and perception of over a thousand people piled into the single space his body occupied. Twisting the weapon out of the Wrexwren's claws, Quorum used it as a blunt instrument, delivering one sharp blow to the head and sending his opponent down in a heap.

"Go." Quorum had turned to Bloopston, still unfazed. "Along that alley, turn left by the fountain, keeping heading north until you see the other AHC members. We're consolidating our forces to root out the nearby remaining invaders. I'll be there shortly."

He was gone, around the corner, off to meet more Wrexwren head-on before they arrived. Bloopston, still shaken, did as he'd been instructed, forcing his webbed feet to move along the paved stone streets. As much as Lodestar and Professor Quantum tended to be the larger profiles at the AHC, this particular cape felt a great deal of gratitude to the less-assuming member of the Champions' Congress, who was out here getting his hands dirty. Granted, Lodestar's fight was obviously essential as well, but

Professor Quantum could have made a real difference out in the field. Who knew how many capes wouldn't be coming home tonight because their calls for backup had gone unanswered?

If the big capes were busy, then that just meant the rest of them had to pick up the slack. Bloopston poured more effort into his legs, eager to find the others. Assuming they had some healing power on hand, he could recover and get back out into the field. Being trapped and helpless, only to have salvation arrive unexpectedly, was an excellent reminder of what it meant to be a superhero.

Time to pay it back. There were others out there who needed help, and next time, Bloopston would be the one running in to save the day.



Hovering in the air, Cliché held in one arm, the in-progress gauntlet in the other, Hephaestus couldn't believe there was a time she hadn't considered flight an essential suit function. She blasted back, toward a hopefully stable section of the remaining floor, and set both down. "You okay?"

"Not especially. That guy sounds serious about killing us all, and I'm not sure this is going to work," Cliché admitted. "Oh, you meant physically. Little bruised on the ribs from your grip, but doing much better than I would be if I'd taken the tumble." Tenderly poking herself in the side, Cliché appeared momentarily confused. "Actually, wait—maybe not a full bruise?"

"If you copied my powers along with my brains, then your body is tougher than normal right now, and will heal quickly. Really wish we had more time to play with the fire-based stuff, but eyes on the prize. As of now, I think this bad boy is our last shot."

Reaching over, Cliché put a hand on the cold metal of Hephaestus's shoulder. "What if it fails?"

It was something she'd been trying not to think about. Calling the guild was out, since most of them were dealing with the invaders, just like the major capes, so they couldn't count on backup. If this didn't work, she was officially out of ideas. Sure, with enough time and tech, there might be a solution; however, with what they had on hand, it simply might be impossible to beat the enemy who'd clawed his way out of the past. Should

that be the case, it was important to remember that they weren't the capes here.

"Teleport out as many of them as will go. Bahamut and I should be able to escape on our own. I don't think Alfred really gives a damn either way, since we aren't with the AHC. Regardless, the guy lacks wings. Take anyone who's willing to teleport somewhere far—another country if you can manage it. Aim for big cities. The kinds of places where capes will have to be present, dealing with invaders. Then get away from the superheroes fast, because we don't want any part of this grudge spilling onto us."

The sudden groan of floorboards had both of them expecting another collapse, until they glanced behind and saw the familiar pattern of kaleidoscope eyes peering past them, into the rubble below, where bodies were already beginning to stir.

"Not a good time for cryptic bullshit, Nexus," Hephaestus spat, focus swiftly returning to the gauntlet-in-progress.

"Then I am pleased to say that I have none to offer. This is merely the point where things grow most interesting, so I've come to see your version."

"Still a little cryptic," Cliché pointed out, though her tone was gentler than Hephaestus's. "I'm surprised you're here, though. With Lodestar fighting a big monster and Fornax dueling an alien champion, aren't there more interesting things to watch?"

Nexus gave a small nod, never looking away from the shifting debris where Medley's tail had just emerged. "Both are worthy of witnessing, which is why I am doing just that. There are a great many tales being told in this chaotic backdrop, and I am carefully observing all of the most entertaining ones."

Very nearly, Cliché almost asked how—except she sensed that that would start a journey down a rabbit hole they very much did not have time for. Instead, she helped Hephaestus with the gauntlet, rewiring at incredible speed, despite her previous lack of familiarity with the task. This was quite a potent saying to keep on hand, assuming the next attempt didn't split her head open like she felt the last one still might.

A voice rang out from below, filled with confidence, perhaps even a dash of joy. Unfortunately, that voice belonged to Alfred, and only made their situation worse. "Lozora, is that you? Here I assumed you'd have

scampered off into a hole once the work began. Turns out, you managed to sneak in. A dedicated helper to the end.”

Hephaestus knew that voice. It was one she’d clung closely to, making sure not to forget a single syllable, and as she listened to Alfred speak, his tone finally landed in her memories. It hadn’t sounded quite the same through the magical fire and distortion of the room, but there was no mistaking that air of shitty smugness. This was the voice they’d heard in the labyrinth, meaning that she’d finally found the one responsible for attacking the Starscouts.

That might be useful in the long term for getting him on Lodestar’s radar, but in the moment, it meant their “trespasser” was exactly what Hephaestus had feared: an enemy in disguise. In fact, her skin’s inhuman hue triggered another bit of memory from the flaming pit’s speech—this Lozora woman was likely the “green little helper” he’d mentioned. Worse, based on everything she’d managed so far, Lozora might also be competent, as well. They were already on the ropes; one more enemy who knew what they were doing could very well put the nail in this coffin.

“So considerate of you. Saves me the trouble of hunting you down later.” After Alfred’s words came a sharp screech, and Hephaestus felt a tad less worried. This was why villains used the guild, for protections against exactly this type of betrayal.

It wouldn’t take him long to finish with his former ally—or anyone else, for that matter. Hephaestus scanned the gauntlet again, searching for any potential way to increase the output. There was no chance the weapon would survive; they’d get a single shot out of this, at most. It had to be cranked to the absolute maximum.

Because if this didn’t work, the only choice they had left was to run, and Hephaestus knew deep down that not all of them would get away. Alfred’s bony hands wouldn’t let them escape.

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## Chapter 121

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From the wounded body of Zerle Salvrin came a series of higher-toned whistles, what Fornax had begun to suspect indicated the presence of mirth. Moments later, the translator kicked in as words sprang forth. “Behold, your mighty champion. She has realized the fight is hopeless, and is fleeing for her life.”

The mistake was understandable. Zerle Salvrin had no context for what he was seeing, no history to pull from. To Fornax, this sight also represented the nearing of the end, though not in the same way his opponent anticipated.

As he was looking up at the ceiling’s screen, Zerle Salvrin launched an attempted surprise attack. To his credit, several blows managed to land before Fornax hit back, once, stunning the Wrexwren momentarily.

By the time Zerle Salvrin recovered, he was being held, head pointed upward, directly facing the screen.

“Fun as playing with you is, this is the sort of thing one rarely gets to witness,” Fornax said. “It’s about time you understood just what your species is truly up against.”

Together, they stood, watching the light burn brighter as it rose through the sky, waiting to see what came next.



The rubble should have been nothing, not to him. From the early days, he'd been strong. Before he learned, trained, grew, and evolved into the man who could lead the New Science Sentries, he'd been born strong. Pressing his hands against the floor, the weight bore down on top of him, trying to hold him back. Out there, he could discern muffled voices, followed by a scream. It could be one of his team, or the other superheroes, even one of the villains giving aid. There was no way to tell through all the debris blocking his ears.

A small voice inside whispered that perhaps it was better this way. Covered as he was, the situation was actually a momentary respite from the beating he'd been taking. The voice lit something in his belly, a self-directed fury at even being capable of such a notion. Pushing harder, arms straining, he forced his muscles to work, despite being weakened by Alfred's energy. Staying put, laying low, none of those were acceptable options for a superhero.

His head swam from the effort, threatening to pass out entirely, and he refused it. Through the blurry vision and near unconsciousness, he could still see the faces of his team... his friends. Ike, so jaded and broken when he'd first arrived, now fighting to protect others. Ellie, starting so nervous and quiet, they initially thought she had stealth powers; it had taken years for her shell to crack and the powerful superhero to emerge. Kyle, who'd been with him from the very beginning, a pair of kids shooting for the impossible goal of carrying on a legacy.

Just when it felt like his arms would fail, one last face swam into view, followed by her gentle voice. "I don't like the idea of you following his footsteps, especially knowing how dangerous it can be. That said, I trust you, and I know this is where your heart is set. So just promise me one thing. Don't be like him, a figurehead playing a role. Be true to who you really are: my superhero."

Something in his back tore, a pain that barely registered amidst the accumulation of wounds piled atop him, as Agent Quantum managed shove aside a massive hunk of unseen material pinning him. He burst forward, getting most of his torso out into the open air. What greeted him was an array of groans and slow movement as a few of the others pulled themselves free. It seemed Agent Quantum had been under one of the densest sections, though there were some still hidden beneath the debris.

Nearby, Alfred was holding some tall woman with skin the color of an old lime underneath. Her face was twisted in pain—no surprise given the way one of her legs was dangling, refusing to bear any weight. Neither paid the newly emerged cape much attention; they were busy dealing with one another.

“You traitorous shit. Why?”

“Same old Lozora, needing explanations instead of just accepting the commands. Because you annoyed me, I wanted to kill you, and now that the job is done, there’s no reason not to. As a bonus, it saves me some pest nipping at my heels, demanding payment that was never going to come.”

As they were fighting, a sudden creak next to Agent Quantum tipped him off to Presto’s arrival before the other man spoke—though not by much. “Things are looking rough. We’ve got one real card left to maybe play. After that, our only option is to hope we can escape.”

Spinning around, he noticed Presto was lightly coated by dust, having taken at least part of the tumble with everyone else. There was also a curious set of goggles wrapped around his left wrist, much too cobbled-together for the New Science Sentries aesthetic. “You heard him—if we run, he’ll kill random civilians until I show up.”

“I’m not so sure about that. Look at when he took his shot: mid-invasion, when all the bigger capes are busy. I don’t think he can afford to draw that much attention to himself. Because next time we show up, it’ll be with the full Champions’ Congress at our backs. That’s the whole point of being in an alliance.”

It was a good point; with backup, this fight could go very differently. And in truth, Agent Quantum didn’t really expect Alfred to manage a nonstop murder rampage if they got out. But people *would* die for it, he had no doubt there. This was an enemy who delighted in hurting them. He’d never miss such an opportunity to twist the knife.

“Thank you, Presto. I know what you’re trying to do, and I appreciate it. Get everyone else out safely. That’s an order.” Turning from his ally, Agent Quantum shoved his legs through the rubble, yanking himself fully free as he faced their attacker once more. “Hey, Alfred! I thought we were mid-game. Get bored of me already?”

At the sound of Agent Quantum’s voice, Alfred hurled Lozora over his shoulder without the slightest care; she hit a wall and slid softly down.

“Never, my boy. I will never tire of tormenting anyone who wears even a piece of that name.”

Moving with intent, Agent Quantum stepped away from the site of the collapse. The others were managing, but they needed time. If he could keep Alfred’s interest, it would give them a chance to recover, and hopefully escape. “It doesn’t have to be like this. What happened to you is clearly a tragedy, but the AHC has resources. They might be able to find a cure.”

“A cure? A *cure*?” Another section of floor darkened moments before Alfred shot forward, backhanding Agent Quantum so hard the cape stumbled back several feet. “What possible need do I have for a cure? Shall I go return to my family, all of whom are long dead? Perhaps I can visit the graves of my friends, marvel at the results of my stolen legacy, or mourn for what might have been. A cure—what a childish notion. The only things in this world that are still mine are this power, and that mid-city patch of ugly concrete they slapped my name upon.”

“This is better?” Agent Quantum wiped the blood from his mouth, or as much as would come away, as he struggled to regain his balance. “Hurting people you don’t even know, hoping the pain carries over to Professor Quantum. Which is *pointless*. Whatever you do to me, we both know he won’t really care.”

For a very strange moment, something passed between them. On as many aspects as these men were polar opposites, there was a shared understanding common to both. They knew the man behind the legend, understood what it was to live in the shadow of the great Professor Quantum. In their own way, both had been scarred by the experience—only one of them wore that pain on the outside.

“I do know.” There was almost a tenderness to Alfred’s tone, which did not match the punch he delivered to Agent Quantum’s ribs, shattering several. “But having his precious legacy ripped violently apart so soon after their debut will hurt the Science Sentries’ reputation. Let the years pile on as they may: pride has always been Professor Quantum’s one true weakness, the place where he can suffer.”

Morose though the moment was, Agent Quantum’s heart suddenly fluttered as he caught sight of a dark armor floating down from the ceiling. Alfred glanced back once, allowing Agent Quantum a chance to strike, which he didn’t take. Knowing the effect such a blow would have, it wasn’t worth the injury to his hands. Right now, he needed to stay whole for as



long as possible—taking the beating was the only way he could hold Alfred's interest.

"Oh, are the others planning something? How cute. Perhaps you're buying them enough time to attempt an escape, now that you've all finally grasped how hopeless things will be? Guess that means you'll have to keep me busy, then." Another punch, this time to the left shoulder, breaking it and sending Agent Quantum reeling.

Even through the pain, however, he kept watching the others. Hephaestus had brought down some woman with a ski-mask and an umbrella just after Alfred turned away, and together, they were rooting through the rubble, searching for someone. Agent Quantum tried to raise both fists, but the shattered shoulder refused to work properly, so he settled for getting the right hand up.

"That's right, I will. Keep it coming. Almost got your timing down."

A bony palm to the sternum cracked it on impact, as well as sending Agent Quantum stumbling back. He was saved from the floor only by virtue of crashing into some of the few remaining kitchen cabinets. Breath was suddenly tight in his lungs—the air had been knocked out of him, adding rasping to injury.

Behind Alfred, light burst forth from the debris. They'd uncovered Plasmodia, who was seated like she'd been meditating, energy crackling along her entire body. Agent Quantum wasn't even sure she'd realized the floor collapsed. Plasmodia was building a charge, focused enough to manage through the chaos. Hephaestus and the strange woman hurriedly grabbed her attention.

"Bastard though he is, at least Professor Quantum is capable of adapting to a challenge. Look at you, the situation so clearly hopeless, yet you persist on playing hero. Do you really intend to take this all the way to the end?"

"Absolutely." Sweat and blood were dripping into Agent Quantum's right eye; he must have cut his head on impact. It didn't even matter. Seeing the punches coming wasn't helpful in this fight. Half-vision was plenty. "I know what happens when you start choosing yourself over everyone else. I've seen what lays at the end of that road. If my choices are to be a real superhero for this one moment or spend decades as a fraud... well, I think I've already made my decision on that front clear."

Ignoring the pain screaming across his body, Agent Quantum lifted his working arm into a fist once more. The others were to his right, in the

blurred-out section of his vision, so he had no clue where they were in whatever scheme they had planned. All he could do was keep standing, and have faith in his team.

Alfred, on the other hand, was in clear view as he lifted a hand, fingers fully extended. That was the form he used for stabbing blows, and gauging by the angle, Agent Quantum had a gut feeling he'd be feeling this one in the gut. "Such a noble sentiment, yet in the end, what did all your suffering accomplish?"

"Well, he bought us enough time to beat you, so that's something." Hephaestus's voice rang loudly through the room, clearly meant to be heard. At the sound, Alfred twisted back toward it, and Agent Quantum was able to adjust his gaze. Now he could make out Hephaestus and the woman wearing the ski-mask, both directly behind Plasmodia, who'd donned one of Hephaestus's metal gloves. Both she and the device were glowing like a sword pulled from the hearth, his fellow New Science Sentry staring pure death at their attacker.

Interestingly, it was the ski-mask stranger that seemed to rile Alfred the most, pointing directly at her. "You! The gall to be in my presence again, and with that vile item in hand no less." To Agent Quantum's shock, Alfred began to stalk across the room, interest momentarily shifted.

While this did move him closer to the others, it also put distance between him and Agent Quantum, meaning Plasmodia had an easier shot. From the whine of the metal glove, it sounded as if she'd hit the same conclusion.

"Really? More of this pointless pageantry. Very well. These are your final moments. Waste them as you see fit." Alfred kept right on walking, and given how unassailable he'd been through the whole fight, it was hard to blame him. Odds were, this would be just like all the other attacks: entirely pointless.

Hephaestus grabbed Cliché as the threat drew near, no longer shouting, the voice still easily carried through the small space. "Weapon is out of our hands now. Can you think of anything to give it some extra juice?"

There was something familiar about the twinkle of her eyes as the ski-mask woman stared down the approaching skeleton, but Agent Quantum was in no headspace to place it, even with the aid of her voice.

"In times like these, only one pops to mind, and I can't think of anything more fitting. **The darker the night, the brighter the stars.**" No

sooner had the words left her mouth than the woman tipped over as she passed completely out, saved from hitting the ground only by Hephaestus's quick reaction time.

Amidst the madness, Plasmodia paid neither of them any mind. Every ounce of her focus was on the still-advancing form of Alfred. She was letting him draw close, making sure there was no chance the shot could miss, even if it meant she'd be in danger afterward.

"On behalf of the New Science Sentries, the original Science Sentries, the Alliance of Heroic Champions, and everyone else you've hurt with your horrible scheme, consider this a message from the bottom of our hearts: Fuck you back to the grave."

Plasmodia fired, and the entire world exploded in light.

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## Chapter 122

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It had never been like this before. Not anything close. Usually, Chloe felt the power shift around a touch with each new saying, like a mild change in the breeze. Even the ones that impacted her physically, she registered differently than the power itself. This was no breeze, however. It was a tornado, yanking her out of metaphorical Kansas and whipping Chloe through what felt like a dozen different spaces all packed into one.

When she finally stopped, there were no sights to behold. Everything was sensation; she was well past the boundaries of the physical world. There was a shape to this place, a form, even shifting as it was. Mentally groping around, Chloe felt a small divot, a break in what should be. At her touch, words drifted into mind—her own words, in fact, spoken to Hephaestus back in that hallway, when they needed to work on the gauntlet.

This was a mark left from using her power. Wherever she was, it was connected to that ability. As she pondered what it could mean, Chloe also realized something else: the break was shrinking. Self-repairing, soon it would be no more than a memory. Continuing on, Chloe tried to get her bearings, to create a sense of this place. There was no time here, making it impossible to say how long she wandered. She only knew that something was leading her forward. It was a peaceful, nearly serene trip... until she reached the edge.

No mere divot this time. Instead, she was at the lip of a crater. Standing there, she could feel her own power flowing into the fracture of reality, reinforcing something much larger and bigger than she was capable of generating on her own. Slowly, Chloe put the puzzle of her situation

together. Before, she'd been the one creating the breaks, her own pockets of the world where things functioned differently. This time, she'd stumbled onto someone else's efforts, and that made for a very different experience.

Today was turning out to be quite the learning opportunity. Not only had she discovered a new use for her abilities, Chloe also learned she wasn't the only one out there who could create these sorts of effects. Except, whoever had made this one was worlds stronger than her—though, with Nexus's warning fresh on her mind, it was hard not to wonder if that gap could be closed. Especially considering the other truth she was realizing.

Based on how much was flowing from her into the crater, Chloe had a *lot* more power than she'd been using, far more than had been leaking out of her last effort. She could feel the connection, and had an intuition that it could be severed when she desired, but Chloe made no attempts to halt the power. Might as well see how much she really had to throw around.

Besides, if this was working as she imagined, then there was no phrase to use where her efforts would bear better fruit. She wouldn't change the tide of the invasion—that had already been sewn up—but there were still untold smaller fights going on across the planet, countless forces facing dangerous odds, seemingly unbeatable forces. This crater was already a thumb on the cosmic scale. Chloe was just turning that thumb into something a little heftier.

Now it was just a matter of seeing how heavy she could go.



Two-on-one were bad odds, even without an injured leg, something that Dapper Doll tried not to dwell on as she leapt to the side, narrowly avoiding fire from their blasters. She had the advantage in physical power, but the ranged weapons kept forcing her back, scoring minor damage from shrapnel when she wasn't quick enough. With buildings to her rear, however, room to maneuver was running out.

There was one shot she could think of: do the unexpected, sprint *toward* them and try to dodge the incoming fire. Absolute lunacy, there was no way she had the dexterity or reflexes to pull off something like that. And yet, in that moment, something in her stirred. A newfound... confidence wasn't the

right word. Certainty. This was the only path forward. She simply had to find a way to make it work.

Hearing the footsteps draw near, Dapper Doll sprang, her feet unexpectedly swift. Whether it was terror or adrenaline, she was faster than she'd ever been before, clocking the movements of her opponents as they aimed their weapons. At the last second, she dropped into a slide, narrowly avoiding the pair of shots that went clear overhead. That got her within swinging distance of the first Wrexwren, just the proximity she was aiming for. A pair of punches sent it reeling; funny, the last one she fought had been a bit tougher, but an upper hand was an upper hand.

One kick to the head put it down to the ground hard, revealing that the other Wrexwren had been drawing a bead on Dapper Doll. That should have been it, end of the line, a shot point-blank into her torso. Except that her instincts had a mind of their own. Rather than duck down like she had before, Dapper Doll used her enhanced strength to push off the ground, leaping into a standing somersault. The Wrexwren shot had been angled low, expecting her to dodge downward, which meant it missed her entirely.

Her move, on the other hand, landed Dapper Doll only steps from the enemy, steps she took quickly, sending the alien down with a few well-placed blows. Scanning the area for more threats, she saw nothing. "Everyone, come on out. Let's keep moving to the evacuation point."

Out of nooks and crannies all along the street, civilians appeared, the ones she'd been leading to safety when the pair attacked.

Now that the fight was done, her hands were starting to tingle, the post-battle drain setting in. Moments later came the pain in her leg, the injury exacerbated by all the acrobatics. Dapper Doll was glad for it, though, because moments prior, she hadn't been expecting to make it through the night. It seemed someone out there was keeping watch over the capes today.



Lodestar was nearing the edge of safe terrain, the limits of what she could wield without substantial risk. With power like this, it was very possible to lose herself, even rooted as she was. Feeling the flood of new energy wash over her, filling her relatively miniscule form with the fundamental forces

of the universe, she mentally turned away from the Scralthor and all the fighting.

To hold on in moments like this, the key lay in remembering who Helen truly was. The first faces pained her heart: Mom, Dad, and David. Why did her mind always go to that night, that hill, where they were waiting for her with the telescope? Next came a vision of Mackenzie, trying to hide her tear-stained eyes as Helen awoke in the hospital.

Lodestar began to fly once more, no longer away from the Scralthor, now on a direct course. Helen's mind flashed ahead, to Faucet Hills on that fateful day she'd been forced to accept and wield the same power that had killed her family. Because the other option had been to standby helpless as Corvix butchered her friends. That was the moment she swore to never be helpless again.

Her shine, already blazing so brightly, only intensified as the memories flew by. After Corvix came Quorum, the loss and gain he simultaneously represented. Faces flitted by faster, friends and people she'd saved, anchors that helped her stay grounded as the world grew enamored with Lodestar. Battles, challenges, enemies, adversaries, one after another they fell, until Fornax.

Ivan's face swam before her, coated in a red mask, staring in absolute shock that his blow hadn't sent her spinning back through the air. In fairness, her face had also been a mask of confusion; it had been so long since anyone threw a punch she really *felt*. From there, it was a chaotic swirl of Fornax and Ivan, sometimes an enemy, sometimes an ally, yet somehow almost always a friend.

New pain filled her as she remembered the way he'd stared up during their final bout, eyes filled with the apology he didn't know how to voice, fully aware of how much it wounded her to bring their dance to an end. To leave her alone on the top of the mountain once more. It was short-lived, soon replaced by the image of Ivan hanging in the void of space, wielding more power than she'd even known he possessed, holding Orion locked in position. The moment he'd helped her see who it truly was that set their roles in this life. For a fleeting moment, she could hear his voice, reaching through the chasms of time.

*Even the Lodestar is allowed to be greedy.*

Things grew brighter from there, as did the soaring Lodestar, now on a crash course with the Scralthor and only picking up more speed. At last,

she'd reached the foundation of her world, the cornerstone that would not give: images of Penelope's newly born, scrunched-up, crying face filled Helen's mind. Fast on its heels were countless memories of holding, teaching, playing, dancing, all with the daughter that was never supposed to be.

The same daughter who was probably watching right now, along with the rest of the world, worrying about what would happen if Lodestar failed. She was counting on the world's greatest hero, yes, but also on her mother. Without a sun, their world would wither and die, and at the even idea of Penelope suffering, Lodestar drowned all the forces of the universe vying to overwhelm her. This thing, this being—whatever it was—would not yield until it was fed, or beaten.

That fear in Penelope's heart wasn't hers alone. It stretched across the entire planet, *her* planet. It had lingered over all of them for long enough. Lodestar locked her fist in position as she increased her speed, charging toward the otherworldly abomination.

Seemed she needed to remind everyone, cape or villain, alien or human, cosmic beast or god or anybody else that wanted to step up, just *who* this planet was protected by.



Across the world, countless small fights suddenly turned, the forces seeking to protect gaining ground on those who were after conquest. It wasn't always enough to shift the tides, but for a great many, that extra bit of speed or oomph in a punch was enough to snatch victory.

In the room with Chloe's unconscious body, a much more direct contest was occurring. Plasmodia's beam wasn't simply hitting Alfred with no effect, like last time. No, this was leagues more powerful, physically driving the near skeleton back, forcing him to raise his hands in defense. A scent of burning bone drifted up from the air, and something gave way, flying off from Alfred. Whatever snapped, he'd had enough, diving out of the shot, which instantly carved through the back wall, opening them up to a view of the outdoors. Plasmodia angled the beam upward as it died out, making sure not to hit anyone below.



The gauntlet fell off her arm in pieces, the entire contraption burned away from the beam's intensity. That had been everything they had, and then some, but it wasn't enough. Alfred was still there, rising slowly to his feet. No one moved, because what move was there left to make? That was their final gambit, and it failed.

"You..." He wasn't beaten, but he also wasn't the same, twisting toward Plasmodia like a serpent rearing to bite. "This cannot be. I have stood against the Science Sentries countless times, wiped out capes and villains alike, even survived an encounter with Fornax. After all of that, I *refuse* to believe the first true injury dealt to me came from one of Quantum's whelps."

As he spoke, the keen-eyed in the room realized something had changed. On his left hand, the ring finger was now missing. Plasmodia's beam hadn't been enough to kill him outright, but she had managed to cause a wound. To his ego more than his body, unfortunately. There was no revelry or humor as he began to stalk directly toward her, hands already extended.

"There's only one solution. I'll just have to kill you all and rewrite history. Starting with the one who caused this unacceptable embarrassment." Suddenly, he wasn't walking anymore, but rather bolting forward on a direct course with Plasmodia.

It was too fast for almost anyone to act. Even if he'd been at full strength, Agent Quantum couldn't have caught up in time. Most of the team was still crawling their way out of the debris, and while Hephaestus was at Plasmodia's side, what kind of aid could be offered? Those bony hands would likely tear through metal just as easily as everything else. There wasn't even room to dodge as Alfred barreled down on her. Plasmodia merely faced the threat head-on, watching as his arm reared back and struck.

Before it could hit, the arm was slowed by a sudden new obstacle in its way. Presto stood there, strange goggles over his eyes and blood dripping from his stomach where the arm went cleanly through, Alfred's hand poking out the other side. Shocked, the room was silent, meaning they heard the slight sizzle as Presto leaned forward, grabbing on to Alfred's forearm, his own flesh burning on contact.

"There's a funny thing about having a power that can kill you if pushed too hard: that issue only matters when there's not something you'd die to

protect. For as much of a limit as it's been, the upswing is I've got one hell of a single-use trick, and you're along for the ride, asshole." Presto sucked in a deep breath, then jerked his head upward, staring past Alfred, into and past the sky, the stolen goggles peering at the dark depths of space.

"One last time, for the people in the cheap seats... ***Big Finish!***"

This was unlike any other time Presto teleported. Normally, he simply vanished, and that was that. On this occasion, be it due to effort, mass being pulled, or overall effect, there was a snap of a moment where the spaces connected. Cold burst forth as air flowed in, a fraction of a nano-second enough to feel the wave of emptiness ripple out from their destination.

The silence that followed felt false. It couldn't be over, not just like that. But it was.

Plasmodia's hand was reaching out, grasping at the point where her teammate had been moments prior. "Presto... why...?"

"Not to be indelicate, but the why is pretty obvious. He knew what we all knew: there was no winning this fight." Hephaestus looked at the still-smoldering hole in the building. While her current system couldn't see much, the goggles he'd grabbed were capable of far more impressive views, daylight be damned. If Presto had really used enough power to die, then there was no telling how far into the cosmos Alfred had been flung. What was more impressive was that he'd had the presence of mind to grab and test new equipment, then formulate a last-ditch plan, all in the midst of Alfred's chaos. He'd had a brain with lots of potential, all of which was now lost.

"No." The voice was near a whimper, and it didn't come from Plasmodia. Agent Quantum was leaned against a set of wrecked cabinets, tears running down his face as he pressed his working arm's fist to his forehead. "Damn it, Ike. Damn it." He swallowed, trying to find some level of composure. "I'm sorry. I should have been better. I should have found a way."

Emotional a scene as it was, Hephaestus's perspective afforded her a good view of the sky, which had suddenly grown *much* brighter. Weirdly, the sun appeared to have shifted position as well, moving at an alarming rate. Except, when Hephaestus checked again—nope, the sun was still in its expected position. Too preoccupied to noticed how Fornax was holding his captive on the livestream, she turned to the others. "Not to undercut the moment, but should we be worried about that?"

Following her pointing finger, Plasmodia looked up as well, damp eyes going suddenly wide in shock. “Oh my god. It’s just like the Day of Two Stars.”

That name was familiar, something Tori had uncovered in her initial research of Fornax; after all, it was all but impossible to learn about her mentor without also reading the history on his greatest rival. As she recalled, the Day of Two Stars was what some people called the fight with Orion, alleging that Lodestar had blazed so bright, the planet’s two light sources became indistinguishable.

Seeing it for herself, Hephaestus could certainly understand how the nickname had formed. There was something horrifying and humbling to see so much power being wielded that it was literally visible from space. Yet even that paled in comparison to what came seconds later.

With most of the Earth still watching, the sky suddenly shattered.

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## Chapter 123

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The term “Scralthor” was a Wrexwren word without direct translation. To the creature itself, such a combination of noises would have had no meaning. The sharp shrills of smaller beings weren’t even loud enough to be an annoyance. Merely background, like the songs of the stars and the hideous buzz lurking within black holes. It had no concern or thought for them as it swam, gobbling up small morsels on its way to a larger meal. Flashes of light and minor impacts had caught what passed for its eye, but they were no more than minor meteor strikes, impossible to break through its tremendous hide.

As it swam, however, the creature noticed a new sound. Rich, deep, melodic, and loud. Increasing in volume, at that. Shifting its attention, the creature could not believe what its senses were saying. Since being spawned in the flickers of a dying nebula, the being had swum and devoured, devoured and swum. Others of its kind were challengers, an occasional threat, but space was large enough for all to swim.

This was not a challenger. This was not of its kind, nor was it fully of the tiny ones. The song thundered all around, inescapable and undeniable. Power, a power that was far older than the creature or any of its kin, rippling forth like the fabric of the universe could scarcely contain it. While the creature had been alive for time untold, it was still growing, still learning.

In that moment, seeing a force so much greater than itself, the creature had just enough time to experience genuine terror. Seconds later, a blow that seemed to fracture reality itself rang out, the shred of light stretching

through the darkness of space. It made no sense, that a being so small could wield such power, but the pain radiating forth would tolerate no second-guesses.

For the first time in its existence, the endlessly devouring creature born from the void of space was being genuinely challenged.



“That’s...”

The first translated whistle reached Fornax’s ears moments after Lodestar’s initial blow. Before their eyes, a tremendous burst of energy tore forth from the point of impact, like a crack made of light splintering across the windshield of the universe. That was merely the spectacle, however. What was visible when the light cleared was the real show.

“That’s...”

Against all known reason and sense, the Scralthor had been sent reeling back, blasted away from its shining snack by one true blow from Lodestar. It opened its mouth, letting out some unseen howl lost in the distance of the void. The creature turned to face this blazing threat, taking it seriously at last, far too late. Another blow sent it hurtling further away, Lodestar proving she had plenty more punches to throw, if needed.

“That’s...”

In truth, Fornax didn’t even need the translator for these words. He’d heard them spoken over and over again through the decades. Sometimes, the language changed, or the voice, or even the form of speech, yet the feeling was always the same. It was the sound of understanding setting in, the audible crunch as delusions of grandeur were smashed apart. Scheming scientists, aspiring gods, invading monsters, horrific villains: they all sounded alike when the reality of what they were facing finally landed.

“That’s impossible!” Finally, Zerle Salvryn got the words out, joining a rich Earth tradition he had no idea he was even part of. The words Fornax had been waiting for, the signal that his work could at last draw to a conclusion.

“Yes, it is, not that she gives a damn. This is what it means to stand against the Lodestar,” Ivan explained. “That is the lid on the pressure cooker of our planet, the limit we cannot rise above, the force that rises to

meet every challenge. Barrage of giant robots, summoned army of demoids, or even asteroid-sized monsters from space. It doesn't matter. It *never* matters. All hope of victory has been stolen. No amount of training, or planning, or effort will ever be enough, regardless of how hard any of us try. Do you understand now, Zerle Salvvin, why the day was lost before it began? Even if there are any Wrexwren left out there, they'll never be a threat to Earth. Getting past her only means dealing with all the hungry beasts of the planet that eagerly await fresh targets."

Fornax couldn't destroy hope, but Lodestar did it by her nature. While inspiring those she protected was all well and good, being on the other end of that equation wasn't nearly so nice. It forced one into the simple realization that some walls could never be climbed, certain challenges left forever unmet. Watching her beat a natural force of the cosmos away like nothing more than a shoplifter's hand reaching for a candy bar, Fornax himself felt the same wave of despair as Zerle Salvvin and anyone else who dreamed of being the strongest. Once they knew how high that bar really was, the impossibility of the task became unshakable.

"There *will* be more Wrexwren." Zerle Salvvin was whistling sharply now, trying to twist his head away from the screen; however, Fornax kept it held firmly in place. "They will find a way to deal with your planet's defender, and you will suffer for this day."

Taking a moment to be sure there were no sudden surprises in store with the Lodestar fight, Fornax moved slowly around, putting his head in Zerle Salvvin's line of sight. By no coincidence, this also gave the floating cameras a good view of both Fornax and Zerle Salvvin's faces as they looked into one another.

"In truth, they wouldn't," Fornax corrected. "Whatever tricks they'd have brought would be irrelevant. Trust me, if anyone, on this subject: Lodestar rises to the challenge. Not that it matters, anyway. Because no more Wrexwren are coming, Zerle Salvvin. You see, we didn't tell you everything about that destructive wave from earlier, did we, Doc?"

The voice came immediately, finally tipping off some of the viewers at home to just how planned all of this had been. Fornax was never in danger; they were toying with the alien who'd challenged Earth, drawing the fight out to make him suffer.

"As a matter of fact, there was one tidbit we omitted. What we used wasn't merely some sort of short-range attack; it was coded into a signal.

And my, you Wrexwren have just as robust an interstellar communications array on your warships as I was hoping for. Capable of reaching across innumerable light years in a matter of moments. I've been watching their systems detonate one after another, never even aware they were under attack. I'll scroll some of their identification codes on the screen, just in case you need proof."

Twisting against Fornax's grip, Zerle Salvrin tried to look away, not that there were any good alternatives to the horror in his gaze. Above, he saw Lodestar smacking down what was meant to be his ace in the hole, now with alien symbols flashing on the side of the image, the names of more downed ships across the stars. Next to him was the twisted joy in Fornax's face, eager to dole out more suffering. Even looking to nothing held no escape, as his mind filled with images of all his kin dying in space without warning.

"You would not do such a thing. To destroy our ships, murdering untold soldiers far from conflict... that is beyond the scope of war."

"Beyond the scope of *your* war, maybe. Humans are a truly unforgivable species. Then again, you came here to invade, to wipe us out. Did you expect to have fewer stakes in the fight? Think we'd be content with merely driving you off? Ridiculous dreams. Ours is not such a benevolent way of thinking. Our kind would sooner rip the moon in half than let a chance for vengeance go unfulfilled. Come for this planet, and know you do so with the life of everyone you care for riding along. Consider the preemptive genocide of the Wrexwren army our version of a warning shot to the galaxy at large."

Finally, Fornax shifted his gaze away from Zerle Salvrin, turning to the cameras. "Because this isn't only being broadcast to the citizens of Earth. Doctor Mechaniacal is using your ship to send this video out to every receiving system out there. A galactic hello, from the hellpit of Earth, in case any other eager aliens have thoughts about sending more invaders." His eyes shifted back, down to the rattled form of Zerle Salvrin. "We'll get to them. First, I believe you and I have some unfinished business."

The truth was settling in. Their previous demonstration proved that not only could they remotely blow up ships, but they absolutely had zero compunctions in doing so. Zerle Salvrin raised an arm, half-forming a claw to strike with, only for the appendage to drop heavily. Nearly there. Just a bit more to finish out the job.

“Zerle Salvrin, I present you with a rare opportunity. Based on the state of your ships and the conditions waiting for your invaders, even the few who survive our signal won’t be able to withstand the wrath of all those other planets you attacked. There is a real chance you may end up being the last of the Wrexwren army. Yet all hope is not lost. Doctor Mechaniacal can still halt the signal before every ship is reached. I’m willing to offer a way out, and make no mistake, this is your only chance to save countless Wrexwren soldiers. Let us see if you are a leader who can also be humbled. Accept that your people are helpless, that you live or die only by our pleasure, that your strength is nothing. I will permit you to beg for your life.”

Releasing the grip on Zerle Salvrin’s head, Fornax slowly took a few steps back, visibly unworried about potential attacks. First, he’d broken Zerle Salvrin’s faith in his physical strength, showing that Fornax was unquestionably the more powerful of the two. Then, he’d broken Zerle Salvrin’s sense of strength in numbers, decimating the forces that had earned him his title. Next, Lodestar destroyed any hope he had that the Wrexwren people would ever be able to overcome this obstacle, making sure he would die for nothing, not even a potential new invasion target. Now, they’d come to the hardest part for beings like Zerle Salvrin, the reason Fornax had needed to knock away every other support before arriving to this point: it was time to break his pride.

A being like Zerle Salvrin would never beg for himself. That was a truth Fornax understood to his bones. Yet the experience of Ivan also gave insight, because even the staunchest of warriors had something they would beg to save—he knew that firsthand. Being the final survivor of the invasion would be a heavy enough burden to carry; to be the last warrior of his species was a concept beyond horrific. A battle that couldn’t be won by strength, the only chance for victory was in weakness, contrary to what seemed to be every facet of the Wrexwren culture.

Unable to read the emotions on what passed for Zerle Salvrin’s face, Fornax nevertheless watched the storm of them flow. Eventually, the Wrexwren leaned forward, using one hand to extend his head slightly, while dropping the three working legs into all right angles, creating a sort of suspended crouch. Not quite a bow by human standards, yet clearly meant to convey vulnerability in the same way. Head angled toward the floor, Zerle Salvrin’s whistles echoed around the room before being translated.



“I ask... on behalf of the Wrexwren species... for time to discuss terms of surrender.”

“Terms? What terms do you think there will be? Which pieces of you we dissect versus which ones we try eating? Terms are for people with leverage, Zerle Salvirin. You don’t have that.” Fornax paused, waiting a moment for reply before deciding the wound needed a dash more salt. “Want to know what’s really funny? There was *never* a point where you had a chance. The only reason you’re here is that someone on my planet wanted to occupy the AHC, so they sent bait to lure you down. And my people decided to make better use of you. Do you understand what I’m saying, Zerle Salvirin? You didn’t even warrant a warning shot. Instead, you *are* the warning we’re giving to rest of the universe. All you’ve been from the start are pawns in an Earth scheme. Countless Wrexwren slaughtered, for nothing more than a game.”

There was a moment where Zerle Salvirin appeared to be on the edge of taking a swing, only to feel the confidence that would back such a play suddenly absent. Every other avenue of hope had been cut off by Fornax. There was no fighting a way out of this, no rescue was coming, and even if he escaped, where would Zerle Salvirin flee to? A cosmos full of formerly conquered planets would have quite a few entities looking for payback against the last known Wrexwren soldier. The only hope of living long enough to preserve his people’s legacy was in front of him—that was the conclusion there was no skirting around.

“Mighty Fornax, great warrior of Earth. I humbly beg of you, please spare me. Let me live on in my shame, a worthless coward weakling. We greatly erred in challenging this world. Your power was more than even the Wrexwren could handle. Please, let my cowering life serve as testament to the collective strength of Earth.”

It had taken some time, yet Fornax delivered as promised. The leader of the invading alien forces, hunkered over, pleading for his life, with most of Earth and unknown viewers across the galaxy tuned in for the show. Beating Zerle Salvirin would have been simple and proved just as little. Breaking him completely was far more terrifying, all the more so to any who’d faced the Wrexwren and their seemingly endless pride.

“That was excellent,” Fornax said, peering down at his former opponent. “You held nothing back. I couldn’t ask for a more earnest, sincere pleading. Well done, Zerle Salvirin.” The words were slightly softer,

encouraging the alien to look up, providing a momentary view of Fornax's boot lifted high overhead. "But my answer is no."

One stomp, a spray of liquid, and Zerle Salvrin was nothing more than a headless torso flopping about on the ground. Soon even those movements slowed.

Fornax, however, was only getting started, gaze darting between the body and the cameras.

"No, because the Wrexwren were garbage, nothing but a species of brutish fodder. You died the way you were always meant to: cut down effortlessly by those with real power. Yet in your death, and the death of your entire species' armed forces, you will serve one actual function: our warning message to the rest of the universe. Because if those of you out there watching haven't realized it yet, Earth is not a place for amateurs. To even face us, you have to get past Lodestar, and the lesser capes at her aid. So if you'd like to test your mettle, feel free to come take a swing."

Fornax lifted Zerle Salvrin's body from the floor, hurling it against the wall, where it collided with a damp thud, largely splattering across the gleaming metal. "But unless you're already the strongest being in your corner of the galaxy, don't bother. We don't want your refuse. We want your conquerors, your kings, your gods and demons. Prey worthy of sinking our fangs into, something that can offer up a proper challenge."

Grabbing the middle camera, Fornax pulled it in close, making sure his rune-covered eyes filled up the entirety of the shot. "Earth is riddled with monsters, and we are all so very... *hungry*."



Rick was shaking. Not violently, not even noticeably, if one wasn't paying close attention. His mother's arms slipped over his shoulders, and even as the logical part of his brain insisted that she was part of this too, it was drowned out by how much of him needed that hug.

How had he not seen... because why would he? How would he? In what world could his dad, Ivan Gerhardt, the plain, dull, middle manager be... no, even the thought was too much. But those words floated back up: "rip the moon in half." Who talked like that? Ivan did, when he was being serious. Such a stupid turn of phrase, yet it had been like a pin pricking the side of a

balloon, and now, there was no way to put back all the realizations that were escaping.

Twisting, he meant to speak to his mother, only to recoil in horror at the expression on her face. Was that pride? Admiration? It absolutely was not the appropriate reaction to a man saying he'd wiped out part of a species and then brutally murdering a beaten foe.

"Why?" That was surprising—he'd thought the question of how would win out, but much of Rick's brain was working on autopilot at the moment. "Why is he doing this?"

"On the immediate level, to help keep the world safe," Janet replied. Not one sliver of hesitation to her voice. She'd been ready and waiting. "In a longer term sense, to help keep us safe."

Now, Rick did throw off her arm, physically scooching over on the sheet. "How does that have anything to do with us?"

Never had Rick seen an expression like what darted over his mother's face. Dark, harsh, determined and set, he wondered how many times she'd had to wear that, given who she'd evidently married. "It has everything to do with us. Your father just walked onto a stage in front of the universe and sent two very clear messages. The first is not to challenge Earth idly, which should give any other potential invaders a long pause before they pester us. The second message is what happens specifically to anyone who crosses Fornax. After seeing what he just did to someone he had no grudge against, would you ever want to incur that man's true wrath?"

There wasn't an easy answer for that. Rick had a hunch it would be a long while before he found any easy answers at all, in fact. Laying his face in his hands, Rick closed his eyes, trying to clear his mind so he could think.

Instead, all that waited for him in the darkness were those horrible eyes with the glowing red runes. Only now, he couldn't stop seeing them embedded on his father's face.

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## Chapter 124

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The sudden cold of metal shocked Lozora nearly as much as the force being exerted. Someone was yanking on her shoulder, trying to pull her up to a standing position, despite her weakened leg. She turned to find Hephaestus staring down, gauntleted hand on her, while the free digits motioned back to where everyone else was either stricken with grief or slowly emerging from the pile of collapsed debris.

“We should be gone.”

Given the state of the superheroes, Lozora could see the wisdom there. Logic said she’d just been double-crossed by the same person who’d attacked them, putting everyone on the same side. But they’d just watched a friend die to save them all. Logic wasn’t necessarily the current captain of decision-making. With emotions running this high, the last thing they needed was an outlet.

Much as she detested the help, there was no way she could escape with her leg’s current condition. Doing her best not to appear annoyed by the gracious assistance, she allowed herself to be hauled up onto Hephaestus’s shoulder and steadily walked out into the hallway. No one seemed to notice or follow. They were all lost in the moment, looking up to the sky, though whether it was searching for their lost ally or admiring Lodestar’s handiwork was anyone’s guess. Only the dragon appeared unconcerned, gently lifting up the ski-mask woman, who was still sleeping soundly.

Together, Lozora and Hephaestus trudged down the hall, weaving their way through the groaning, injured bodies of her former crew. The capes weren’t going to come down easy on this group, not with one of their own

now dead. All the better to get clear before they started arriving. Nevertheless, she didn't trust such a kind gesture, even as she needed it.

"I'm surprised you didn't want to stay with your friends back there," Lozora noted. "One of them seemed to have gotten knocked out."

"Which is why Bahamut's job is to take her somewhere to get help," Hephaestus explained. "Sorry to disappoint, but you weren't the first item on my checklist when the dust settled. You're not even the first thing I picked up. Still, with the capes always having each other's backs, we villains have to look out for one another occasionally, too. Otherwise, those saps will always have the upper hand."

Though "enemy of my enemy" wasn't the most original reason to lend aid, it was one Lozora could wrap her head around. Desperation formed strange alliances; she'd seen that borne out a great many times through her unnatural life. Besides, it wasn't as if she had some item or information worth stealing. With her employer disposed of, Lozora would have to start all over again. Perhaps this next time, she'd take a few solo jobs to build up some funds, then form her own crew.

"The way you say villain, I take it to mean you're part of the club." This meta-suited fellow was clearly not Fornax—aside from him being broadcast on television for everyone to see, he would never hide in a fake identity when a real fight presented itself. Plus, Fornax shouldn't even know she'd had a hand in trapping him and his daughter. Nevertheless, it didn't hurt to sniff around, just in case.

"Only in the most technical sense. I made it through initiation, haven't really done much since then. Getting access to backup is great, though. Makes this life not so scary, having people to turn to, especially considering how capable some of them are."

There was no arguing that point. Even Alfred—such a strange name to put to the man she'd known all these weeks—had acknowledged the strength of the guild. That was why he'd taken pains to keep them busy. Finding herself suddenly helpless and in need of aid, Lozora was less dismissive of the notion than normal. "You may be right. Perhaps it's time I gave consideration to the benefits of working together." Turning down a new hallway, they were nearly to the stairs, which Lozora's leg was already groaning about.

"You should know up front, getting in isn't without risk. Some of tests can kill you, and even with the help of mentor, there's no promising you'll

make it through.”

Lozora bit back a scoff only by necessity; she couldn't risk offending the person hauling her around. “I've been on the scene longer than this admittedly embarrassing situation might indicate. Normally, I'm quite a force to be reckoned with. The man was simply... anomalous.” Some metas were just too strong. The world didn't play fair, not every fight was winnable. Learning that early on was one of the keys to surviving in their world.

Round a new bend, only to find a pile of moaning bodies and huge, torn-out chunks of wall blocking the path. “Crap, looks like Medley or Bahamut got rowdy over here. We'll have to circle around.” Together, they continued back down the last hall, passing the turn-off to the blockade. There was another set of stairs at the far end of the building, made for fire emergencies. Not as spacious, but it would work, or failing that, a window could allow them to fly out.

Lozora was so lost in thoughts of escape, she didn't quite notice the way Hephaestus adjusted his grip on her, the same way he'd had to several times already. That this movement also shifted the position of his gauntlet ever so slightly was a detail that would have grabbed her attention on a day with less occupying her mind.

At last, they neared the edge of the hallway, one that would give them access to the outside. Lozora felt so thrilled, her leg even seemed to stop hurting for a moment. “Seems as if we're fr—”

The sound of blasting energy and sizzling flesh interrupted Lozora, followed swiftly by horrific pain rising out of what used to be the middle of her torso. She collapsed, already dying, yet kept conscious by her own damned durability, which even now struggled to save what was plainly lost.

“Like I mentioned, the guild sometimes gives mentors to new members. Some are better than others, and at first, I thought mine was a terrible fit. Still might be, on a technical level. But Fornax has been the only person consistently in my corner since a very long time ago, and we do share at least one core philosophy.” Hephaestus paused, looking right into the dying eyes of Lozora.

“Actions have consequences. You fucked with my mentor, which was bad, but understandable. Then you brought his kid into it. So you don't get to die in a grand battle or display. You don't deserve to face a living legend and fall by his hand. Your ending is here, led to a hallway far enough away

that the capes wouldn't have arrived in time, even if they had heard the shot. Die alone, helpless, knowing you'll be forgotten, and understand that this is still getting off easy."

Hephaestus couldn't fathom what Ivan would have done in her place. Something more creative, and certainly more painful, but she was working with what she had. An energy beam at point-blank range left minimal room for delicacy. Didn't hurt to be safe, so Hephaestus headed back to a section where bodies were piled up. From one, she rooted around and produced a gleaming object, its sharpness flashing in the flickering hallway lights.

Who brought a machete to a meta-fight in the first place? Well, it wasn't like she had room to complain. This would make hauling out her second prize of the day much easier. Moving swiftly, Hephaestus hurried back to the corpse, already aware of the wicked work that awaited her.



The stream cut out just before Ivan turned away from the camera, forcibly reasserting control. That had been a dangerous dance. More than once, his darker impulses threatened to overwhelm the proceedings, but the staged nature of the pageantry helped Ivan keep his head straight. Having a pseudo-script kept his mind on the next task, prevented it from reveling in the pain of the moment.

Across the chamber, the giant doors parted to reveal Doctor Mechaniacal and Xelas, both of whom were splattered in some of the Wrexwrens' internal workings, though neither looked nearly as much of a fright as Ivan.

"How are we doing?" Ivan asked.

"Based on reports from the ground, the initial invasion waves broke against our shores as expected. Most have already been killed or captured. How well they're being treated depends on who snatched them up. There are a few still trying to go down in a blaze of glory, but mostly the AHC is now dealing with humans who sought to take advantage of the confusion."

Stepping in, Xelas added, "Plus, we blew up every ship in our solar system not originating from Earth, so there are no reinforcements to send."

"Which just leaves..." Ivan trailed off, looking up to the screen overhead. The Scralthor was retreating; there was no other possible

interpretation of the situation. This massive beast was sent fleeing by the burning light coursing through the stars. In a very odd way, Ivan felt kinship with the creature. He knew that feeling, that fear, it was experiencing far too well. “Seems Lodestar has the Scralthor handled.”

“Which means she’ll soon turn her attention to Earth, and us, so we should be gone before then,” Doctor Mechanialcal suggested. “Anyone need to use the restroom before we get in the ship? Mostly looking at you, Fornax, as you’re the only flesh-and-blood body up here.”

It took some doing for Ivan to tear his eyes away from the screen. Seeing her like this stirred up a lot of memories, not that this was the appropriate time for any of them. Ivan yanked his gaze away, looking to his allies. “I’ll hold it somehow. It’s not like we’ve got a long trip.”

Together, the three of them hurried through the vessel, occasionally passing scenes of grim carnage telling the story of what happened to the ship’s remaining crew. Evidently, he hadn’t been the only one cutting loose up here. Ivan couldn’t even imagine what sort of havoc the guild as a whole had wreaked upon their targets.

No sooner was Doctor Mechanialcal’s ship safely out of range than the final Wrexwren vessel detonated, blast briefly lighting the sky before it became nothing more than a mass of floating wreckage. Some would make it to Earth, but the AHC had systems in place to break up any chunks that were too large, so they’d burn up one way or another. That would be the final reminder of the Wrexwren invasion: a bastion of debris that occasionally lit the sky when a piece tumbled into the atmosphere.

It was, to Ivan’s thinking, exactly the sort of memorial he wanted. A clear warning to any extraterrestrials who came calling of what they could expect from starting trouble with the planet called Earth.



Chloe’s eyes snapped open without warning, followed by her drawing a large gasp of air, despite the fact that she’d been breathing steadily the entire time. It was like she’d burst forth from a deep pool, blinking at the sudden onslaught of light and sound.

In seconds, Beverly was there, holding her friend steady by the shoulders in case of vomit.



It took a few seconds for Chloe to come all the way back, to leave that unreal place fully behind. She wasn't sure she succeeded, in truth. Something felt different from before, like she was more connected to whatever systems her power influenced. She worked hard to put that out of her mind for the moment, along with deeper concerns of what she'd seen. Chloe was neither cape nor villain, and had no serious desire to be either—at least, for the moment. Digging into the sorts of questions her vision raised would invariably drag her deeper into that world, so she simply chose to ignore it. Sometimes, the classic tactics were still the best.

Able to pay some attention to her surroundings, Chloe realized they weren't at the apartment, or a hospital. For a fleeting moment, she was seized with terror that Beverly, unaware of what else to do, had brought her to the guild. That notion was quickly dispelled. She didn't imagine the guild guest quarters to have a huge antique sewing machine, or pictures of family that bore a striking resemblance to Beverly.

"What happened? Where are we?"

"My guess on what happened is you used too much power in a short span of time. I don't think we've ever heavily cycled your sayings like that before—might be a toll, though you'd know better than me on that front." Beverly paused, looking around her surroundings as if seeing them for the first time. "As to where... I wasn't sure what to do with you. Everything seemed stable, but you wouldn't wake up. I figured step one was to get you somewhere safe, a place I could trust, then find someone to help once they wrapped up dealing with the invasion."

Loud noises came from some ways outside the door, a commotion of bustling and voices all yelling over one another, until a quiet one silenced them all. Beverly, looking more sheepish than Chloe had ever seen her, seemed to take that as a cue to press on. "I brought you to my family's house. A few of them have field medic training, in case you took a turn for the worse, and there are enough munitions to drive back an actual force of aliens, let alone the scraps wandering the streets."

Chloe was still moving sluggishly, like her energy couldn't catch momentum. Realizing where some of that juice might be flowing, she hurriedly switched her active saying. "**A penny saved is a penny earned.**" The change wasn't instantaneous, but there *was* a change. Instead of her power flowing out of her like a sinking rowboat, it felt more akin to a giant

jug, one where the overflow began to accumulate. While she wasn't suddenly bursting with gusto, the dull ache in her head did quickly vanish.

"Where are the others? Did everyone make it out okay?"

The pain that flickered across Beverly's face gave away the ending of her tale before the first word was spoken. "We won, in a way. But there was a price."

Before the conversation could spiral into the true depths of despair, noise rose from outside once more, this time closer to the door. Beverly looked from her patient to the room's entrance, visibly doing speedy mental math on how this would play out. "It wasn't Tori. I'll explain the rest later. For now, it looks like it's time to meet the family."

Perhaps on cue, the door burst open and nearly a dozen people poured through, all eager to meet Beverly's newest friend, and perhaps discuss why their kin had arrived in the shape of a flying dragon.

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## Chapter 125

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Upon return to the guild, Ivan was both surprised and grateful to hear that Tori was waiting for him in his office. Pausing only long enough to call Janet, checking in to be sure his kids were safe, Ivan hurried to the designated meeting space, one he rarely had use for in these facilities. It wasn't as if Pseudonym welcomed many callers, or made efforts to. He truly hoped that wouldn't change now that Fornax had made a special appearance, but life had taught him the world was rarely so kind.

The first thing he noticed after walking through the door was the state of her armor: banged up, missing a gauntlet, and with more than a few pieces torn out, exposing bits of wiring. The second thing he noticed, which *should* have been the first, was the burlap sack oozing a green puddle on the corner of his desk.

"What... who is that?" Ivan had seen enough decapitated heads to know what they looked like when stuffed into a bag. Why one was on his desk was a genuine mystery, on the other hand. Tori had been expected to lay low during the invasion. If things turned messy, that would be understandable, but it didn't account for why she would bring a severed head to him like this.

"It's a thank-you present," Tori explained. "For everything you've done. For being around even after the mentorship ended and you didn't have to. For teaching me how to be a villain."

After a day like this one, Ivan had more or less run out of tolerance for things like cryptic hints. He opened the bag himself, stunned in confusion

by the unexpected bolt of familiarity. “Lozora?” Ivan’s head shot up, looking Tori over in a brand new light. “How... Tori, did you kill her?”

“I had some help. Her employer pulled the oh-so-shocking double-cross and left her injured. I took advantage of her weakness and confusion, then blasted a hole through her middle. The head was easier to transport. Plus, it just felt right, considering the context.”

The context? Tori had no idea about the context this implied. Lozora was not some no-name minion. She’d been around for decades, and that was before being hurled into Rookstone. His former apprentice had just taken out an actual player in their game, the sort of move others would take note of, to say nothing of the allies who might come looking for payback.

“I see. Mind if I ask how, exactly, this is a present for me?” Troublesome as it all was, Tori was nothing if not rational. With everything she did, there was a reason. What remained to be seen was if it was a good one, or not.

Any traces of a smirk fell from Tori’s face as she looked back to the bag. “Her employer was the mystery man who set up that whole Starscout-labyrinth situation, and that green bitch was the trigger-woman. She’s the one who put Beth in danger.”

Whatever trains of thought Ivan had been engineering were instantly knocked off-track by that revelation. It changed a great many things about the circumstances, including how much fallout he would allow to get near Tori. Killing wantonly wasn’t something he’d wanted to encourage, but paying back what was owed? That was a different matter entirely. “Tell me everything.”

Which was exactly what Tori did, laying out the labyrinth voice’s cryptic hints, the visit from Nexus, the attack on her apartment, and the revelation regarding Alfred Settler, a tidbit which actually managed to draw surprise from Ivan when it was reached. She wrapped things up by explaining how the fight ended, quickly detailing her moment of thievery followed by tricking Lozora, then escaping. The only bits she may have skimmed over were those involving Chloe’s power, where possible.

“Damn.” As she spoke, Ivan had pulled some plastic wrap from in his desk, coating the head-bag and putting triple layers on his desk to prevent more general ooze drippage. “Some capes dying today was inevitable, but I’d have preferred all of the blame to be on the wiped-out aliens. At least

this guy wasn't one of ours. If anything, we can cite our members who offered critical help in dealing with him."

"Did you know about him? Alfred Settler?"

Ivan finished cleaning the head juice and wiped off his fingers, exuding a moment of magic to burn his hands clean—not that the rest of him wasn't still coated in Zerle Salvrin's internal workings. From within his desk, he produced a bottle of fine liquor, one he reserved for special occasions. "I knew about Alfred Settler in the same way as everyone else: a piece of history that died in our new world's creation. The meta you're describing rings a bell. We crossed paths here and there—I once had to belt him to send a message, but I punched a lot of people in my heyday. He wasn't part of the Order of the Final Dawn, though, meaning I never had any reason to care beyond that."

"So you wouldn't know... or maybe, could make a guess..."

"I have no idea if he's alive or not," Ivan intervened, saving her from finding a way to ask the question without sounding afraid. Of course she was afraid. Tori was too smart to experience something like that and not better understand her place in the world. She was stronger than humans, yes, but in the world of metas, Hephaestus was still barely starting out. Understanding the difference between what power lay at the summit and how much she could muster would make anyone afraid. "Were I to guess, I'd say yes. Doesn't seem like the type to need air or food, and given the durability you've described, space alone may not finish the job. That said, while he might still be alive, Alfred has effectively been taken out."

From another drawer, Ivan produced a pair of glasses, setting them both down in succession. Tori watched the act, waiting until he was about to pour before speaking. "Just a sip for me. I've got more work after this."

With a nod, he poured her enough for one toast—all they would need. As he moved on to his own glass, which got substantially more, Tori continued, "How do you figure he's gone, if he might not be dead?"

"Between our respective run-ins and the general rumors I've heard of such a figure, he has no movement-based powers to speak of. No flight, no teleportation, nothing that would permit him to navigate the far reaches of space. If he is alive, he's stuck out there, waiting to be found. The only ones capable of such a feat are ourselves, and the Alliance of Heroic Champions. If they find him, he gets Lodestar. If we find him, he's going to wish the AHC had. Either way, won't be much of an issue."

There was an implied “for now” that neither chose to comment on. In a world like theirs, when reality was such a fickle enforcer, nothing could ever really be taken for granted—not until they were dead, like Lozora. That was the price of living in a world of miracles.

Shifting forward, Ivan set the less-filled glass in front of Tori, then lifted his own. “I didn’t know Presto, either as a cape or a person. In truth, he likely would have been an enemy in almost every circumstance imaginable. Yet today, his bravery and determination helped keep my former apprentice... my friend, safe. To Presto, one who deserved to chase the title of superhero.”

“To Ike.” Tori whispered the words, more to herself than to Ivan, before gulping down the single mouthful of liquor. It was excellent, yet horrible, for reasons that had nothing to do with flavor. “Okay, and with you brought up to speed, it’s time for both of us to go clean off. I need to meet with Doctor Mechanical in a few. This is the perfect chance to kick off our new project, and we’re not going to miss it. After that, don’t expect to see me around outside the lab for a bit.”

“Got new plans in mind?”

There was real danger in Tori’s smile, a look Ivan knew all too well. When faced with a power that much greater than themselves, most people’s reactions fell into one of three camps. The vast majority were scarred by it, forever made afraid by the knowledge that there were some limits they simply couldn’t overcome. Some took that pain and grew, however, resolving to be as strong as they could, to minimize how many times that gap would appear. Then there was the third group, the ones who saw how high the mountain stretched and were filled with one all-consuming notion: if they can be that strong, then so can I.

“Lots,” Tori confirmed. “It’s time for a updated model—past time, really. Especially now that I’ve got a lead on a new material. One that can stand up to the leagues I want to play in. A long road ahead on that front, though, so I’m jumping in as soon as possible. Not going to have as much free time pretty soon.”

Ivan watched as she set the glass back down, keeping it a healthy distance from the head-bag. “Care to elaborate?”

“Nah, it’ll be more fun to let you see with everyone else. Time for a shower, anyway.” Tori slowly pulled herself from the chair, suit not moving with the usual grace in its current condition.

“Before you go...” Ivan wasn’t quite sure how to phrase this. It had the potential to be taken wrong, but he and Tori generally understood one another fairly well. Sometimes, it was best to just plug ahead. “Tori, are you *sure* you want Hephaestus to be the one who killed Lozora? She is not unknown, nor without friends. I won’t deny you the glory you’ve earned, but there is much less baggage if Fornax did the deed. Otherwise, you should expect eventual consequences.”

“When the guild reopened, you asked me what kind of villain I want to be.” Tori’s eyes darted from the bag to her right hand, still clad in the killer gauntlet. “That head is my answer. I want to be the kind of villain people fear, because they should. The person no one dares to fuck with, knowing what awaits them. The world needs bogeymen, things to rightly fear. I want everyone to understand what happens to those who cross Hephaestus, or her guild.”

It was a path Ivan knew all too well, one he’d just recommitted himself to on intergalactic television; he had no room to cast judgment, no matter how much he wished she’d found a safer road to travel. But Tori Rivas didn’t want normality or safety, and only she could live the life that was best for her. Even if it meant one that might end up significantly shorter.

“Then we tell the truth. Hephaestus killed Lozora. Make sure that new suit is a good one, Tori. You *will* have enemies coming to test it.”



The first coherent thought Donald had was when the cocoa burned his tongue. That sharp jolt of pain finally yanked him from his reverie—a mix of injury, exhaustion, and emotional fatigue. By the time all of the other superheroes climbed free, the fight was over. Presto was gone, and the rest of the New Science Sentries were near inconsolable. Since then, Cyber Geek had been running on what felt like autopilot, forcibly putting one foot in front of the other.

Backup arrived eventually—they’d caused too much destruction to not get noticed—and from there, they’d all largely been swept into more experienced hands. He’d gotten some texts from Tori that they were evacuated, but safe, which left him with nothing to do except dwell on the

fight they'd just had. On how, once again, he'd been ultimately useless when the threat turned severe.

The gruff voice in his ear might have caused him to leap right up, if the cocoa hadn't already brought him partially out of the fugue. "It wasn't your fault." Ren's rough hand fell on his back a moment later.

"How did you know?" Donald didn't even glance up from his Styrofoam cup. He couldn't stand the same zoned-out stares on the faces of the other capes in this area: a place for those who'd seen too much this night to decompress.

"Because Ren feels the same way, just like the rest of us." Lucy plopped down to his right, still clad in her costume, save only for the mask. "We're all aspiring superheroes. We all take too much responsibility when things go wrong. He's right, too. In this case, there was no victory to be had. Presto... he saved us."

Tears welled up in Donald's eyes. He'd barely even known Ike, but this was the first time he would be burying a fellow superhero. That fact alone was scary enough to draw the waterworks. "There might have been ways to escape."

"There weren't." Irene took the final spot near him, sitting closer than she normally preferred. "Not without risking innocent lives. Presto saw the chance to make a difference. He had the ability to matter, the opportunity to act, and the willpower to see it through. That's what it takes to be a superhero, if only for a moment. He made the hard call to keep us alive."

In a way, that was true, but largely by coincidence. The real people he'd been protecting were the New Science Sentries, none of whom were currently in the same room. Probably off for a debrief—the same treatment his team would be in for once they'd had a chance to recover. With the chaos of the day, everything had to be tackled in waves. The ones who needed more time were shuffled around to the end of the queue.

Last time he'd been in a real pinch, he'd made it through thanks to the power of his team. Today, it was thanks to another superhero, one who wouldn't be around to pitch in next time. Donald was tired of being saved, frustrated to feel like he was making progress only to hit one wall after another. Yet painful as it was, his other choice was to accept that weakness, to simply say that this was the league where he could play and leave it at that. Be left behind by the friends who were taking time to make sure he was all right, even after living through the same hell themselves.



He had to get stronger; only now, Donald was starting to understand that this wasn't some temporary condition. For as long as he lived in this world, he'd forever be climbing, striving, reaching just a bit higher, all in the hopes that the next time they hit a major threat, he'd be the one making a difference, not another person getting saved.

Presto had perished protecting them all. Next time, Cyber Geek wanted to make sure no one had to die. Not if he could become strong enough.

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## Epilogue

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“I’d like to thank you all for being here today.”

That opening was the only traditional thing about the morning’s event, the strangest funeral Tori had ever attended, though she’d really only been to a few. None of those had been in bars, however, let alone ones rented out for private mourning. The others had also had dead bodies present; in the case of her parents, barely recognizable ones, but bodies all the same. While this was not a traditional funeral, it did feel fitting. Presto hadn’t really been a traditional cape.

“I put a lot of thought into what I could say about Ike Pemberton, whether I should lay more emphasis on the man or the mask to eulogize him properly. In the end, I realized that to honor my friend, there was only one clear choice: I have to emphasize the truth. Because almost above all else, Ike hated bullshit.”

Austin’s line drew a small chuckle from the audience, meager as it was. Aside from her, Beverly, and Chloe, all seated at one small table, the crowd largely consisted of the remaining New Science Sentries, Cyber Geek’s team, and a few strangers Tori didn’t recognize, along with one she very much did. As a newer cape, Presto had gotten little time to make an impression. The world would mourn their hero through the AHC’s public memorial and upcoming ceremony for all those lost in the invasion. Today was for those who knew the man beneath the moniker.

“That trait could make him abrasive, hard to work with, and even harder to befriend. It also kept him honest, upfront, and one of the few voices I could always trust to tell me when I was making a mistake. Ike valued truth

over sentiment, and would hate nothing more than being held up as a saint just because he passed. Ike was our dear friend, and also an asshole much of the time.”

A loud sniff from Ellie in the front, though she was holding up better than Kyle, who was already crying openly. Some folks cracked smiles at the sudden swearing, but there were no titters this time. The moment no longer felt right for such mirth.

“I’m not going to stand here and tell you that Ike had the natural disposition of a superhero, that he was always fated to fight for the side of side of good. None of that. Yet even though he didn’t especially like them, he still used his power to help people. In the end, Ike passed us all up, going out in the most heroic way I could imagine, saving the rest of his team.”

Chancing a glance over her shoulder, Tori noted that the woman standing at the edge of the room wasn’t crying. The look on her face was more severe, almost guilty looking. There was no logical reason for the woman to wear such an expression, but Tori understood why it was there. This sort of failing probably always felt personal to her.

Standing at the bar, which they were treating as a makeshift podium, Austin lifted his glass, and the others followed suit. Tori wondered what the capes would say if they were to learn that the world’s most feared villain had lifted his glass to Presto in the same manner. Sadly, posing such a query would essentially be opening a case of worm-filled-cans, so some things had to remain a mystery.

“To Ike, a reminder that the seeds of true heroism can spring from any one of us, when defending what we love. I’m sorry you had to save us, and I promise we’re not going to waste the second chance you provided.”

An echo of “To Ike” rumbled through the bar as everyone tipped back a glass, toasting to the cape missing from the room. Since the invasion, apparently the AHC had begun scanning space, searching for Alfred or Presto’s remains. No luck so far, which was about as expected, given how much area they had to scour. It meant there was no corpse to lay to rest, however. Instead, they were gathered around one of Presto’s spare costumes, laid out artfully inside a glass case.

With Austin’s speech done, some of the crowd headed over to the bar for refills, while others trekked to the bathroom with relief in mind. As for Tori, she decided it was time for light mingling, making her way around to the back of the room where the lone figure had been watching from the

shadows. Her target made no effort to escape, even as Tori drew close enough to speak softly.

“I didn’t think Ike warranted a personal appearance from Lodestar at his funeral.”

“He most certainly did. Unfortunately, when she shows up, the focus shifts from where it’s meant to be, so I’m here instead,” Helen replied. She wasn’t in a disguise, necessarily, though her outfit was more stuffy and professional than Tori would have expected, creating a different vibe altogether. Tori wondered if she’d have recognized Helen were she not in the know about her secret, and just how potent that identity cloaking of hers really was.

“Do you always go to cape funerals?”

“Not always. Job often gets in the way. All the ones I can though, yes. It’s the least I owe them.”

Did she really feel guilty over not being there for Ike? The woman had been battling a space monster intent on eating their sun, a fight that only she could have won, protecting the entire planet as a whole. Maybe that was what it cost to be so powerful; when you could do anything, it meant what you chose to save was all the more important.

“How have you been?” Helen broke Tori out of her reverie with a slight turn and a friendly smile. “With Starscout meetings temporarily suspended, we haven’t gotten to catch up in a couple of weeks. I was glad to see you made it through alive. Especially knowing what a good helper you can be to your friends.”

Her eyes darted pointedly to the rest of the room, making it clear she knew what Hephaestus had done but had no intent of airing that secret out here. It was bizarre, realizing Lodestar was keeping tabs on her. That was likely unavoidable, one of the encumbrances of being Fornax’s apprentice.

Thinking of Ivan made Tori uncomfortable. She had no idea how Lodestar reacted to the guild’s move against the Wrexwren. News outlets had called it horrific, unconscionable, an extreme overreaction. Tori, on the other hand, had gotten to see the results. It wasn’t as if the world had suddenly become a clean and sparkling utopia—there were still a great deal of criminals out there, all at varying degrees of morality. However, after Fornax’s appearance, the guild was suddenly deluged by debts being repaid and oaths of loyalty being reaffirmed. Most of the rule-skirting had thinned out quickly, helped along by the guild’s new commitment to enforcing their

edicts. They would never be powerful enough to influence every action of every criminal, but they were once again a threat to be considered. Worse than before, in many ways. Under the old system, they'd been a rumor; now, they were fact.

"I've been okay. Mostly busy with work. In fact, I've got a big event later today. Thankfully, they didn't set this at the same time."

"Glad to hear it," Helen replied. She rummaged around in her pocket, producing a small white card. "In all our time together, I don't think I ever gave you my number. Shoot me a call if you need anything, Tori. Even just perspective or guidance."

Despite an initial wave of hesitation, Tori accepted the card. Odd as it might be, having direct access to Lodestar was not something she was dumb enough to pass up. There might well come a day when that phone call saved her life, or the lives of her friends. "Holding out hope I'll switch over?"

"Let's just say that I think anyone willing to put their lives on the line in a fight that isn't even theirs has superhero potential. You can call about other issues, too." She checked her watch, then noted that the official part of the funeral seemed to have wrapped up with the speech. "As for me, time to get back to it."

Tori was mostly braced for the hug farewell—she'd gotten accustomed to Helen enough after their few weeks together—though it was still bizarre knowing who had their arms around her. After pocketing the card, she turned to find Kyle walking over, a pair of beers in hand.

"Do I see Tori making new friends of her own free will?" He handed over the spare drink as he arrived, which Tori accepted. In truth, it was hard staying sober at this event, not only because of the palpable sadness in the air. The timing couldn't have been worse. After working so hard to get things ready so fast, their big premiere *had* to come on the day of Ike's farewell.

"More like making small talk." Tori instantly realized she should have come up with a better lie—by this point, Kyle knew she hated that sort of chitchat—but the words were already out, so she took a long drink to cover them. "How are you holding up?"

At her question, he paused to wipe his shining cheeks. The tears had halted, but their effects remained. "Good as can be expected. The AHC was able to mend my injuries, so at least I'm not out a job, too, but losing Ike

was a bigger blow than any of us were prepared for. Doesn't help that Professor Quantum already wants to start interviewing replacements."

That did seem soon, after little more than a week and change. Then again, how long was a superhero team expected to operate a member down? Getting a replacement might be safer, not that Tori was quite socially inept enough to voice such a notion.

"I'm not sure if I ever said this or not, but I wanted to come over and apologize," Kyle continued, halting only for a healthy sip of his own drink. "Our team was the reason you all got put in danger. They were using you to draw us out." A dark laugh slipped past his lips. "It seems like every other time we talk, it's me apologizing for putting you in danger."

"Yeah, seems about right," Tori agreed. "Maybe you should stop."

The words hit like she'd kneed him in the groin, so Tori hurried to elaborate. "Stop apologizing. You fucked up once and got me exposed, there's no sugarcoating that, but it was only once. Everything the world does following that isn't on your shoulders."

"Be that as it may, we're not going to let it happen again. When the apartment building is repaired, we won't be there. Another team can take over protective detail, one with less baggage of their own, inherited or otherwise."

Had this news come on any other day, there was a good chance Tori would have leapt upon it. A chance to be free of the New Science Sentries, with no suspicion on her in the process? But today wasn't that day. Not with what they'd lost, and with the twist of the knife she knew was still coming. She couldn't steal this, too.

"Look, the water takes forever to get warm, our front door lock sticks, and people keep pissing in the alley out back, but it's not that bad of a place to live. No need to go running back to your fancy superhero lair just like that."

"Tori, I meant—"

"I got what you meant. You want to move to keep me safe. Well, guess what: I'm *not* safe. Because the world isn't safe. Shit happens, human or meta, and we all do our best to muddle through. You want to leave, by all means go ahead, just don't do it for me. Live where you want to live, how you want to live."

This time, the drink nearly drained half of Kyle's glass. "Maybe it's just because of where we are, but that almost sounds like something Ike would

say.”

“He was a smart guy, when he wanted to be.” Tori checked her own watch, realizing that time was nearly up. Crap. She’d wanted to talk to Donald, too, give him a proper warning. “Listen, I have a meeting to get to. Sorry to duck out early.”

“No, we understand. The perils of holding it on a weekday. Just when we could get the time; things have been crazy since the invasion.” Between rebuilding, missing persons, and general chaotic fallout, Tori could imagine how thin the capes were spread at this point. The world was steadily coming back together, though. That was the silver lining of surviving multiple worldwide catastrophes: humanity was getting adept at bouncing back.

Tempting as it was to bolt on that, Tori had to say something; otherwise, it would go over even worse. “Before I head out, I wanted to let you know... look, Kyle, I think of you guys as friends. Ellie, Austin, Donald, Kyle—those people. Not the masks you wear. Keep that division in mind, and please believe me when I say none of it is personal.”

“What does that mean?” Kyle said, noting the way she was already edging toward the door.

“You’ll see. And this time, for what it’s worth, I’m the one who’s sorry.”



Sitting outside the house, Rick thought the day was too nice. This wasn’t how the world was supposed to feel after horrific revelations. It was expected to be gloomy, drab, morose, tainted by the new perspective he’d obtained. Instead, there was sunshine and mild winds, a perfect final day before fall’s true onslaught. The world didn’t care that everything had changed for him. It just went right on turning how it pleased.

A slam of a car door jolted him into the moment, one brief warning sign before Beth came scampering up the drive, clad in a hat with a stuffed shark on it. Not far behind was Ivan, Rick’s father and a homicidal villain who’d tortured a sentient being on live television, only to eventually crush his head. If only those were separate entities, instead of being crammed all into one body.

“We missed you at the aquarium today. They had some new exhibits, one last big event before school restarts.”

Ivan sat down next to him on the bench, one Janet had picked up years ago and restored to sit outside her home. Or had it been stolen from a dead superhero’s lair? Rick really had no idea how much of what he thought to be true actually was, save for some points he’d have much rather lacked clarity on.

“I wasn’t feeling up to it.”

“That’s what your mother said.” Ivan sat there, listening closely as Beth dashed through the house, on a direct track for the bathroom after getting a whale-sized soda. He waited until he was sure she’d left earshot. “You figured it out.”

“Is it that obvious?” Rick wasn’t sure what words were coming out of his mouth next, nor why he’d waited out here in the first place. Things had spun so far out of control, he barely understood his own thoughts at this point, let alone actions.

Slowly, Ivan nodded. “Frankly, yes, but I knew it was just a matter of time. You’ve got too much of your mother’s wiles to not put the pieces together eventually. There is more to the story than you know, than my old reputation would let on. Though it doesn’t change what I did, nor excuse it. I am a man who has lived a strange, terrible, occasionally wonderful existence, and I own every choice within that life. Including last week’s display.”

“Display?” The word got choked halfway through, like even his own throat couldn’t believe that that’s what Ivan was calling it. “I watched my dad beat someone to the brink of death, make them get down and beg to live, then kill them anyway. I don’t... what the hell am I supposed to *do* with that? With who you really are?”

“Make peace with it, or reject me from your life entirely. Those are my guesses for how this eventually goes,” Ivan replied. Still calm and steady, same as he’d always been. Except now, Rick knew how deep those still waters ran, and what sorts of terrors were waiting down below.

Could he do that? Kick his dad entirely out of his life? It was entirely viable, given his age and his mother’s awareness of the situation; Rick just wasn’t sure he had it in him. Because on top of the images of Fornax wreaking havoc, he couldn’t stop seeing flashes of Ivan, of his dad. Nights spent on homework, working as a chaperone on school trips, offering



support and guidance wherever possible. Rick's father was a rock in his life, something he'd always counted on, and the idea of losing it scared him nearly as much as knowing about Fornax. "Would you be okay with that, if I did reject you?"

"Okay with it?" The calm demeanor cracked, and for a flash, Rick could see just how deeply hurt the idea of that left Ivan. "It would break my heart losing even a piece of you. To be cast out entirely would leave a wound no meta-human or monster could ever dream of matching. No, I would never be okay with it, but I *would* respect your choice. I grew up being forced at every turn, chained to my destiny. Your life is yours, and if I'm no longer welcome in it, then it's on me to deal with that fact. I did my best as a father, but sometimes, the past refused to stay buried."

"You're the one who dug it up. Who went on TV, who wore that mask... Fornax was gone. Supposedly dead long enough that he was more legend than history. You brought him back, Dad."

Sounds from inside betrayed that Beth was done, and Ivan didn't want to be lingering on this conversation if she popped back out for a second goodbye hug. Best to be heading out, anyway; his day wasn't finished yet. "Yes, I did. A choice I made; one I don't regret. Because even if you never understand why, Ivan had just as much reason to be in that fight as Fornax. They were coming for our planet, threatening *my* children."

Another break in the calm; however, this wasn't a flash of pain. Instead, Rick saw his father's determination laid bare, and even a glimpse of that was staggering. Staggering, and ferocious. There was no limit in that gaze, only absolute will. Whatever was demanded of him to keep them safe, Ivan would rise to the occasion, even if he had to stand on Fornax's shoulders to do it.

"Oh yeah, that's what I feel right now. Overwhelmingly safe."

Ivan rose to his feet, departure imminent. "When you look at the stars, are you afraid of what might be out there? Given that a previously unknown sentient race tried to invade us barely more than a week ago, it would make perfect sense."

To that, Rick said nothing. He realized the answer in his heart, as did Ivan, but speaking it was a step further. Instead, he managed to shake his head, just barely.

"No. Because you know the monsters that any aspiring invaders will have to get through first. And now, so does the rest of the galaxy. It will

break me to lose you from my life, Rick, but understand that no matter how things go between us, I will never stop keeping you safe, protecting you, and loving you. None of the powers, title, accomplishments—nothing in that world matters more to me than you and Beth.”

“Then *why* did you choose to resurrect Fornax?” Rick demanded.

“He was necessary, and though it would make my life somewhat easier, I truly hope you never have to understand why.” Ivan started to go in for a hug out of habit, then halted when he caught Rick’s stiffened posture. “If you ever have questions, want to know more, or want to just talk, I’ll answer them honestly. No more secrets worth hiding, not after that one. Until then, I’ll give you space to think.”

Ivan didn’t look back as he walked to his car. It was a silly point of pride, but he loathed to let anyone see him cry.



“Are you sure? The results keep ending up the same.” Beverly stared at her friend, concern evident on her face.

She and Chloe were alone in their apartment, despite the building still undergoing repairs. A huge tarp still clung to the side of the brick complex, even as people came and went through the front door. It was incredible, the speed with which their home was being rebuilt. Only two nights in a hotel were needed, then they’d been able to move back in to their miraculously untouched apartment. Several areas were closed off, and obviously, the owner of the room where the New Science Sentries had fought Alfred Settler was going to take a lot longer for repairs, but other than the steadily shrinking hole in the building’s side, Beverly was amazed at the rate of their home’s recovery. Amazed to the point of suspicion, in fact. Since Thuggernaut assured her that the guild wasn’t gassing things along, her current guess was that the AHC was speeding the process through for the sake of the New Science Sentries.

“Only from your side,” Chloe replied. “I can feel myself making progress. Not as much as I might like, but every time we do it, I hold out a little longer.”

“And that’s worth the migraines?” The skepticism on Beverly’s face made it clear how she felt, especially as the one who had to carry Chloe’s

unconscious body every time. “You really want access to dragon forms that badly?”

Looking away, Chloe chewed her lower lip for a few seconds, mulling over the question. “It isn’t about your powers, specifically; they just happened to be the right setup I needed. Something out of reach, but not by an impossible amount. What I’m really trying to figure out is if I’m capable of growth. Can I get better, my power stronger, or is this what I’m working with for the rest of my life?”

“Be certain that’s a rabbit hole you want to go down. The stronger you get, the harder it is to stay on the sidelines,” Beverly cautioned.

This time, Chloe didn’t need consideration time for her response. Instead, she lifted the pink and black umbrella resting at her side. “I accidentally killed someone in my first real fight, when I got this souvenir. Then, it managed to block an attack from the otherwise unstoppable bone-guy, pissing him off in my direction. Whether I like it or not, sometimes this is a dangerous world, and I’m not going to ignore my power when it could help save my life or that of someone I care about. Still no desire to do that professionally, I’m just tired of feeling helpless on the sidelines. If I’m going to use this power, then I have to be able to control it, maybe one day even understand how it works. All which is to say... yes, I think figuring out growth potential is worth the migraines, even if it does cause me more trouble down the line.”

Worried as Beverly was, she couldn’t find much fault in Chloe’s logic. With everything that had happened, it was no wonder she didn’t want to feel helpless, to her power or the strength of others. Besides, the truth of the matter was that this was now the second time having Chloe around might well have saved her life, the first being that same fight where Chloe had distracted the umbrella’s original owner. Without her helping Tori on the gauntlet, drawing Alfred’s fury to Plasmodia and causing Presto to make the ultimate sacrifice, Beverly genuinely wasn’t sure if any of them would still be alive.

More than that, though, she realized Chloe’s sentiment echoed her own. Fighting Alfred had been a stark reminder of how far behind the meta-curve all of them were in the grand scheme of things. Beverly herself had begun experimenting again, attempting to draw out new dragon forms without luck. Knowing her own frustration, she didn’t have it in her to refuse someone else the chance to make progress.

At last, Beverly relented. “Fine, but only just the once. Last time we went for two, your nose started bleeding.” She walked over, sitting down on the couch next to Chloe, who was already propped up carefully with her back braced on cushions.

Taking deep breaths, Chloe centered herself and looked Beverly in the eye. “**Anything you can... do...**” Her eyes were attempting to take on the sharp green of a dragon’s iris, warping and flexing, shifting in place, yet unable to stabilize. “**I... can—**” Chloe’s shifting eyes snapped shut as she collapsed backwards into the cushions, passed out on the spot.

It was the result Beverly had been expecting, the same one they’d gotten every time Chloe tried this since the day of the invasion. A phrase that let her copy someone’s capabilities—not just their power, but something like Tori’s talent for mechanics—was incredibly powerful, and Beverly had been as eager as her friend to see someone else take on a dragon form. Unfortunately, it appeared there were some limits in place as to how much Chloe could handle. Someone who could do a single phase-shift was evidently not as draining as turning into a multi-formed magical shifter. Or perhaps it was something to do with their power sources. As Tori had put it, “With only two points of data to consider, any conclusion we draw is basically a glorified guess.”

But the activity hadn’t been entirely a waste. As Chloe’s training partner for this exercise, Beverly had kept careful track of just how far into that saying she could get before losing consciousness. Although Beverly hadn’t been sure at first, today was the first time she found real certainty in her observations. Chloe had been squeaking ahead a syllable at a time, and today, she got out a full word further than she had on their first try.

It might take a tremendous amount of time and effort, but she had a hunch that Chloe was indeed capable of growing stronger. Beverly wasn’t sure if she was more curious or terrified to see what that power could do when fully realized, but she was damn glad it was in the hands of a friend rather than those of an enemy. Fists and fangs, even strength like Alfred’s, she could wrap her head around. The power to do near anything, assuming one could find the right words—that was *truly* terrifying.



Ivan and Tori were together backstage, waiting for the call. There was no technical reason for him to be present. The project was publicly between Wade and Tori, secretly between Doctor Mechaniacal and Hephaestus—neither situation called for Ivan’s talents. No, there was no need for him to be here, but after everything they’d gone through, Tori and Ivan no longer felt much requirement to justify their presence around one another. He was her teacher, her friend, and in some ways would always be her mentor. Given how long Tori had been entirely on her own, it was nice to feel like she finally had someone to lean on.

“Nervous?” He knew it was a silly question, one asked purely for the sake of talking. Tori’s pacing through the room made her emotional state plenty clear without any words needing to be spoken.

“Terrified,” she admitted. “The hell was I thinking? I can’t go on camera. On live TV, at that. I come off as surly with just normal socializing—add in nerves and I’ll probably call the host a pig-fucker or something.”

With minor effort, Ivan smothered a chuckle before it could reach his lips. “Give yourself a little credit. You’re not the same thief with an attitude problem Wade put in front of me. Over the months, you’ve grown exceptionally well into your civilian identity, even getting along with our most mundane of coworkers. Besides, the hard part was shot last week, and editing can make anyone charming. All you have to do is go out there with Wade and do the introduction. After that, everyone’s focus will be on the screens.”

“Uh huh. See, I know that rationally, but the twisting nerves in my stomach just refuse to listen to reason.” Tori glared down at her own stomach, as if angry at her body for not being more stalwart. “Let’s talk about something else. Any news on Presto or Alfred?”

Solemnly, Ivan shook his head. Considering that the cape’s death had saved two of the guild’s own members, it was deemed appropriate to use some resources to search for Presto’s remains, as well as the potentially still-living Alfred Settler. Ivan was a man who believed in repaying debts, both the positive and the negative. He owed both of those men proper burials, though one might take more work to prepare for the grave.

“Figured that was a long shot. How about Lodestar? Have you heard anything?”

“Still haven’t been able to get in touch. She’s been busy helping put the world back in order. I imagine whatever fate she has planned for me, or

should I say, Fornax, she'll get to it when time permits." Ivan resisted touching his phone, checking for a text or phone call that he knew wouldn't be there. Thus far, he'd only gotten one commination from Helen, a single text reading "We'll talk later" and nothing more.

Tori's pacing slowed momentarily. "Fornax's fate? The hell are you talking about? You fought back an alien invasion, put yourself at risk to keep the entire world safe, and covered the AHC's ass in the process. Hell, you even praised their leader for the world to see. What are they going to charge you with, defending the Earth?"

"In the eyes of the law, I've done no wrong," Ivan agreed. "But Lodestar is not the law. Her power is far beyond such human concepts and limitations. I think now, at last, you all better understand that."

The flash of terror in Tori's eyes told him she was remembering the same sight that the rest of the world had seen play out on video screens billions of times since the invasion. Although no one knew where the recording had come from, thanks to Wade's technological adeptness, a mysteriously high-res video of Lodestar's triumph over the space monster began circulating before the invasion day was even finished. Ivan had spent too long being the only one who truly understood just how strong Lodestar was; it was nice to have company in that existential dread.

"Yeah, that was... well, impossible seemed to capture it best." Tori hesitated, her curiosity and fear battling with one another over the prospect of more information. In the end, as it always did, her curiosity took the upper hand. "Can she really do anything?"

"Not anything," Ivan corrected quickly. "There are a few limits we've learned through the years. She's bad with intangible enemies, can't travel through the multiverse, and at the end of the day, she's still only one person, with all the limitations that implies. However, if she truly believes in what she's doing, that she's in a fight that must be won, then she *will* triumph. That's why I live in fear of the day Helen no longer wears that title."

Her pacing had come to a total stop as Tori grew more invested in the conversation, her focus helping to settle her nerves quite a bit in the process. "About that. I get that you like Helen, and so do I, but you've said the power passes on. We'd still have a Lodestar, right?"

"Yes, we would, and they would be a force of good—the power always seeks a suitable host. That said, what is and isn't 'good' has many subjective pieces. We've scanned the multiverse time after time for various

reasons, and while every person who carries that power is on the side of the capes, they don't always share Helen's sense of empathy and compassion. To put it bluntly... now that you understand just how powerful Lodestar really is, that *none* of us could stand against her, how many people do you know that you would trust with that strength? With that level of unchecked, absolute power keeping watch on the world? Because for me, the answer is exactly one."

Tori's anxious energy dissipated as she sat heavily on the couch across from Ivan, a thousand-yard stare settling down in her eyes. "Now that, I get. A more authoritarian Lodestar could reshape our whole world in a matter of years, especially with the AHC at their disposal."

"Precisely. Add in that Helen is an actual friend, and you can see my concern, admittedly misplaced as it is. Even among the Lodestars of the other worlds, Helen is exceptional." Ivan should know. He'd been there when she bucked the system and broke the rules—except, that wasn't really how it worked for Lodestar. She didn't break the rules. Even when she thought she did, it was far scarier than that. Lodestar *changed* the rules, sometimes without even realizing she'd done it.

Tori leaned forward in her seat, pushing the couch cushion to a precarious edge. "Why is that?" Most in the guild would have let the cryptic statement hang, but Tori's love of learning easily outpaced any sense of respect for unspoken secrets. Luckily, she was clued in enough that he could give her part of the answer.

"A few factors, but the most important of which is her bonds to other people. This is, admittedly, some speculation, but I believe Lodestars are designed to slowly lose their connections to the world they protect. As time goes on, the job wears them down, the burden of that power becomes too heavy to bear. Being the absolute strongest is a lonely proposition, especially when the whole world counts on you. Slowly, they lose the fire to fight, and the next time they're pushed, the power moves on, finding a fresh host filled with the desire to make a difference. Even Helen had some rough patches along the way, but she managed to stay connected to friends, enemies, and some who fall in the middle. She's held her sense of self for an already impressive amount of time, which let her grow into the power more than most. But all of that was just the warm-up, because *very* few Lodestars have children. She didn't even think it was possible for decades."

“With Penelope in the mix, there’s no way Helen will run out of will to fight,” Tori realized. Unfortunately, she also had the mind of a villain, as well as someone who’d recently seen the depths some criminals would stoop to. “That also makes the kid a vulnerability, though. If anything happened to Penelope, would Helen be able to hold on?”

There wasn’t an easy answer for that, so Ivan didn’t try to give one. “I’ve no idea, and have worked very hard over the last few years to not find out. That is not a version of Helen, or Lodestar, I ever want to see.”

Leaning back into her couch, Tori let out a long breath. “Well, that’s sure not going to keep me up at night or anything. Thanks for the eventual existential crisis, Ivan.”

“You could always look on the bright side,” he suggested.

“Which is?” Tori’s words were barely out before the knock at the door brought her jerking back to the reality of the situation, just in time to see the wily smirk on Ivan’s face.

“I took your mind off the stage fright, didn’t I?”



The gun clattered onto the concrete, knocked away by a barely seen blur as it whipped by, seconds before a powerful blow knocked the crew’s muscle two feet off the ground before landing, visibly dazed. With their muscle pushed back, the others were exposed. They turned toward the street, hoping to find some passersby that might serve as makeshift human shields. None were within reach, and as the blur did a sweep around the perimeter of the bank, they realized that was no coincidence. The New Science Sentries hadn’t just been drawing fire. Tachyonic was clearing civilians every time they were distracted.

Agent Quantum walked up to their stunned brick of meta-muscle and executed a simple trip, sending him to the ground without inflicting any more damage than necessary. Half the crew tried to make a break for it, only to have the ground in front of them sear and bubble as burning hot beams of focused energy tore forth from Plasmodia. There was no getting away that easily, not unless they were willing to take their chances on her aim, which didn’t really have to be *that* good to hit under these conditions.



The blur stopped next to Agent Quantum, marking the first time in the fight Tachyonic had slowed down enough to be seen. “Area is clear. No civilians left to be in danger.”

“Good job. That means we can wrap things up.” Agent Quantum looked over the crew, many of whom were still reared up and spoiling for a fight, not content to be taken out so easily by some rookie team with a spotty record. Eyes flicked to Plasmodia, guarding the rear, and Tachyonic, always at his side. The missing presence pained him. No taunting voice or vanishing form. Perhaps that was why the words found their way to his tongue and felt strangely right perched there. Agent Quantum wasn’t especially prone to improvisation, but he knew when to listen to his heart.

“New Science Sentries...” Despite the ache in his soul, Agent Quantum’s mouth still twisted into a smile as the words broke free, a moment he liked to think Ike would have appreciated. “Time for the Big Finish.”



“Isn’t that Tori?”

Lucy’s voice startled Donald. The team had been largely silent for the last hour, seated in the general AHC facilities, mentally recovering from Presto’s funeral. The New Science Sentries were already back on patrol—everyone handled grief in their own way, and it seemed that team was the type to work through it. As for Donald’s group, they had no pressing business, and after a morning of heavy workouts all around, had simply fallen into a state of rest, save for Ren, who was doing pushups in the corner next to Irene reading her book.

Only Lucy had been paying much attention to the communal television, set to a local news station in case of emergency information being broadcast. Donald had appeared to be napping, though he was in fact cycling through his lists of items and games, trying to find something that might have helped in the battle with Alfred Settler. It had become his new hobby, or a reincarnation of his previous one. Before the powers and items, Donald was just a guy who loved gaming, and one component of that was loss. Failure was part of games; it was why they had multi-life mechanics. But he’d yet to find any item trustworthy enough to bet a self-resurrection

on, which meant he had to make sure to learn his lessons well when he was lucky enough to survive. He'd keep digging until he found a viable strategy. Even if Settler was gone, there were other dangerous threats out there—no reason a sound tactic couldn't be used elsewhere.

Pausing the programs with an opening of his eyes, Donald realized that Lucy was right, that was indeed Tori on the screen. The subtitles were a few seconds behind, so he missed the initial context. It seemed like she was being interviewed in a nice place, lots of natural light and gleaming fixtures. When the camera cut away, it was to a genial face framed by a fading hairline of copper. Donald nearly fell back in his chair. What in the hell was Tori doing on the news with famous billionaire Wade Wyatt?

Hopping up from his seat, he darted over to the side table near Irene, where the remote was sitting, quickly turning up the volume. His movement also got Irene and Ren's attention, both of them taking note of a familiar face on the screen. Finally, Donald found the sound button and clicked it.

“—which is what inspired me to reach out through the corporate chain and speak to Mr. Wyatt,” Tori finished. She was clearly nervous, though not rattled, voice surprisingly calm and steady despite her body's occasional fidget.

The screen cut back to the reporter, a generic, handsome face Donald couldn't have picked out of a news anchor lineup. “Is it standard policy for the company's owner to hear out such requests from employees?”

Another cut, this time to Wade Wyatt, who was in no way showing the slightest bit of unease. He looked as if he'd been born on camera, a genial grin fixed in place and a sparkle of brilliance shining from his eyes. “As a matter of fact, Indigo Technologies and all subsidiaries have many programs for advancement that self-starters like Tori have used to get attention on their excellent ideas, though her case was indeed special. Learning what one of our employees went through, I reached out to see if there was anything she needed that we could provide. And lo and behold, what does she say? Not a request for more time off, or even a joke about hazard pay. No, Tori Rivas took that opportunity and told me she didn't want this to happen again. More than that, she had ideas for how to make a difference, if I was willing to listen.”

Tori looked almost sheepish as the camera returned to her for a few seconds, circling around to Wade Wyatt once more soon after. “I think

we've teased this out enough, don't you? Let's let Tori tell us, in her own words, about the new product line from Indigo Technologies."

"The hell is all this?" Irene had closed her book, getting up from the chair just as the interview cut out, switching over to prerecorded footage.

"Genuinely no idea," Donald replied. The screen was currently showing footage of Tori's kidnapping, the event that had catapulted her right into the public's eye after Tachyonic gave her the initial bout of exposure. Watching the attack on his friend hurt, filling Donald with a desire to show those jerks what-for, if any of them were still alive.

The clip didn't show it all, just the highlights, as Tori's voice began to play. "My name is Tori Rivas, and if you know me, it's as the woman who recently got snatched off the streets of Ridge City— despite me having training." The clip showed Tori's attacks to the kidnappers' joints, brutal and accurate as she made them work for their prize. "Despite the crowds nearby." A new angle, flashing on the multitude of bystanders who'd stood idly by as the fight took place, some even having produced their phones. "Despite all of this happening in the Alliance of Heroic Champions' same neighborhood." Now the shot was of a sweeping view of the city, giving context for the few blocks that separated Tori's point of abduction from the home base of what was supposed to be the greatest superhero organization in the world.

Tori was on-screen again, but not in cobbled-together found-footage, nor as the stiff woman giving a live interview. This was still prerecorded, and apparently, with enough time and takes, she could manage to smother her discomfort. She looked right down the barrel of the camera, expression bordering on severe. "We live in a dangerous world. A world where the balance of power swings wildly from person to person, and often, there's no telling who, or what, you're up against until it's too late. While we appreciate the help of superheroes and their organizations, there's no denying the fact that they can't save everyone. In light of the recent invasion, that has become all the more clear."

"What is she talking about?" Ren was no longer working out, a true testament to how attention-grabbing Tori's interview was. "We fought the Wrexwren back on the first wave."

"We won," Lucy agreed, a touch of melancholy in her tone. "Just not for free. Innocents still died, people lost their loved ones. The big victory

doesn't always seem so worth it when you're the one who has to pay the price."

Much as Donald felt like he should ask more about that, Tori was speaking again, and this wasn't a situation where he wanted to miss the details.

She was standing now, walking forward down a white hallway. "What you might not know about me is that I'm more than the internet's favorite damsel of the moment. I'm also an inventor, a problem solver. So, after experiencing that terror for myself, I decided that next time would be different. And thanks to the generous support of Indigo Technologies, we've been able to make that ambition into a reality."

A podium appeared in frame as she kept walking, holding what appeared to be a handbag and collection of accessories. Tori scooped up the bag, showing it off to the camera. Under her breath, Donald heard Lucy whisper "So cute!", probably without realizing she'd spoken aloud.

"This was our starting point, the product launching this week, from which we've already grown. A seemingly simple purse capable of releasing a toxin that will render all but the most powerful of metas incapable of action while you make your escape. It's also compliant with all federal regulations for self-defense weaponry, and specifically engineered to keep it from being used by even the most fashionable of criminals."

Her hand wandered now, tapping on a few of the featured accessories. "A small preview of some upcoming options we think you'll find especially useful: video-recording earrings with remote cloud storage for evidence, lipstick that can create incredibly painful dermal abrasions, watches with sonic charge capabilities—an entire arsenal hidden in plain sight. If you're like me, if you feel the same fear of this world's dangers, then you don't just want a weapon. You want an armada, an ambush waiting in your hand for the next time someone decides you look like an easy target."

Gesturing to the display, Tori graced the camera with her first real smile of the whole spectacle. "With great pleasure, I'm honored to announce Indigo Technologies' newest line: the Rivas Personal Defense System. Because it's about time we were allowed to save ourselves."



Ivan hadn't been sure what to expect from the knock at his door. Most people who knew this address would also be the type to reach out before heading over. Of course, the surprise made more sense when Ivan saw who was standing on the other side. After over a full week of radio silence, some conversations needed to be done in person.

"Helen," he greeted, looking around his townhome's entrance courtyard to see if there were any other people to overhear. "Would you like to come in?"

"Sorry, can't stay for long." She rummaged around in her purse, producing a small stack of pages and handing them over. "Just came to give you these. Congratulations, Ivan, your sentence as a Starscout leader has officially come to an end. When the cluster reopens, they'll have new, permanent staff for the kids. I already vetted everyone myself. There won't be a repeat of the Haywood incident."

Moving without thinking, Ivan accepted the papers, unfolding them to reveal exactly what had been described—an official notice from the Starscouts thanking him for his time and explaining the leadership handoff process. "Thank you. Stability will be good for Beth, especially after all the excitement."

"Of course. Any child welcome *means* any child welcome, and so long as that organization uses my likeness, they're going to uphold that tenet." Helen looked him over, not quite able to hide the awkwardness that now lay between them.

Tempting as it was to let her walk away while the mood was still polite, Ivan couldn't permit the moment to pass. He had no idea when the next chance might arrive. "About the other stuff..." he began, before Helen put a single hand on his chest.

"Ivan, I have always known who you are, and what you're capable of. Do you really think you need to explain this to me, of all people? That I don't already know it was for your kids, yes, but also about maintaining order the only way you knew how. I think, deep down, maybe even a little bit of you thought it was for me, saving me the trouble of working toward peace with invaders that had no taste for it. I understand your reasoning. I just... can't accept it."

"The world is safe," Ivan pointed out.

"At what cost?" Helen looked up, and he realized that her eyes were watering. "Even beyond the loss of life you caused, did you ever think that

maybe there were things beyond this planet worth knowing about? Technologies, medicines, new ways of living we could benefit from, all of which are likely lost to us now, because you just painted Earth as a backwater hellpit that no sensible species would come within a hundred lightyears of.”

He nodded, already aware of the effect such a message would have. “A necessary risk to ensure our planet is left undisturbed.”

The hand against his sternum turned into a finger, poking him roughly. “Because *you* decided it should be that way. *You* made that choice for all of humanity, for untold generations to come. That wasn’t your right to decide.”

“Forgive me if I have trouble taking that critique from *you*.”

The tears were fading fast now as anger began to outpace sadness on Helen’s emotional spectrum. “Do you think I sought those choices out? That I ever wanted to make them? I am tormented daily by the fears that I made the wrong decisions along the way and set something in motion to doom us all. But at least I was trying to think of everyone when I made them. All you were thinking about was yourself, about the kind of world you wanted. Congratulations, Ivan. You got your way.”

Her rage petered out toward the end. Fury was never Helen’s strong suit, unless she was truly motivated, and on those occasions, even Ivan ran for cover. Part of him wanted to reach out to her, yet once again that day, Ivan felt the distance separating them keenly.

“Helen, I did what I thought was necessary to keep the world safe. I’m sorry if you don’t agree with my methods, but the low body counts alone speak to how efficient it was.”

“I know you did, Ivan. Like I said up front, I’ve always known who you are,” Helen said, a distinct tinge of sadness unmistakable in her voice. “It had just been so long, I guess I let myself pretend otherwise.” The sigh from Helen was long, as her hand finally moved away from his chest. “Even if you break a chocolate bar in half, it still has the same calories.”

A fear unlike any Ivan had experienced in battle gripped his heart. “What does that mean?”

“It means that you and I are a pair of unlikely friends. Best friends, sometimes, when things aren’t so complicated. After everything we’ve gone through with and for one another, I don’t see that changing quite so easily. But you also reminded me why that’s the most we can ever be, no matter how nice these last few weeks have been.”

She didn't need to explain herself any more than that; not to him. He too had been enjoying their temporary partnership, a facsimile of domestic life that perhaps other versions of them could have enjoyed. Unfortunately, no matter how Ivan and Helen felt, Lodestar couldn't take up with Fornax. Even their friendship pressed at the edges of acceptable morality. Lodestar was the golden standard the world looked to—a scandal like that could undo literal decades of positive work for the world.

Moving carefully, watching for any sign of resistance, ready to halt, Ivan reached out and lifted Helen's chin, their eyes meeting in the lonely courtyard. "I understand."

"I *know* you do. That's part of why it hurts." She put her hand over his, gripping it tightly. "Another world, another life, huh?" Wielding inner strength that had nothing to do with Lodestar, Helen pushed Ivan's hand back to his chest, patting it once. It wasn't the first time either had spoken those words to one another, though the occasions never seemed to get any easier.

"Who knows what could have been," Ivan said, finishing out the phrase. "I'll give you some space for a while."

Helen nodded, despite the pained look on her face. "Penelope has a dance recital next month she'd hate for Uncle Ivan to miss. Let's see how we're feeling then." For a moment, she looked over her shoulder to turn before pausing. "Goodbye, for now."

"See you in a few weeks." Ivan had wanted to say goodbye, as well; however, his tongue betrayed him, refusing to form the words. Not to her. For Helen, this was the most he could manage.

Ivan stood in his doorway, watching her leave, waiting until the courtyard gate clanged closed, and for five minutes afterward before finally closing the door and heading inside.



Sparks flitted from the shattered television, remote still embedded in the glass near dead center. Professor Quantum paid them no mind. He'd get around to fixing or replacing it when the need arose. For now, the art-piece on the nature of rage soothed him every time he looked at it. How dare that ungrateful little whelp use her position to slander their reputation in an

attempt to build her own. Was it not enough that the AHC had given her and that guild adequate room to commit their atrocities thanks to “respecting the law?” Had they not dispatched Lodestar to her aid, in spite of knowing there were resources already willing to save her? This was her repayment? A line of products built on the assumption that the superheroes would fail?

His office door opened without warning, which meant there was one of two people who should be walking in. Only fellow members of the Champions’ Congress were permitted such free entrance, and moments later, he was relieved to see Quorum appear. The last thing he needed right now was one of Lodestar’s tiring speeches.

“Afternoon,” Quorum greeted. “Stopping by to let you know we moved the call with the Defense Department to five—only time we could get everyone you wanted on at once.”

“I am up to date with all emails and changes to the schedule.” Professor Quantum tapped his device—calling it a phone would be a genuine injustice to the amount of technology bundled inside. “I’m also too busy to bother with politeness. What do you need that had to be said in person?”

The brusqueness didn’t bother Quorum—who knew if anything did, really. He was truly impossible to get a handle on, the amalgamation of over a thousand unique voices and perspectives creating something wholly unique, and unnatural. “Very well. I came to tell you not to make any moves against the woman.”

While Professor Quantum briefly entertained the notion of playing dumb, there was little purpose. Quorum might not be a meta-genius; however, he had excellent observation and deductive skills, not that the embedded remote left much need for speculation.

“I could hardly help it if someone anonymously tipped off a few reporters about the new Indigo Technologies spokeswoman living a secret, villainous life. It’s not as if her identity is protected by the Orion Protocols the way that beast’s is.”

“Which would accomplish nothing, at this point,” Quorum explained, having already seen the situation from that and untold more angles. “Tori has no warrants for her arrest; she is at most wanted in connection to a minor museum robbery that insurance has already paid for. If you expose her now, she can pivot, using the chance to come out into the open about just *how* advanced her creations can be. Building a suit for self-protection already fits into the narrative she’s spinning, and currently, you’d have little



support internally for trying to move against her. Hephaestus was on-site helping the New Science Sentries in their battle. None of them will care more about one potential heist than that.”

It was frustrating, being told that what should be such a simple fix would only end in error, but one ignored Quorum’s insight at their own peril. “I suppose you’ll advocate we take the high road and only strike through proper channels.”

“There would be no point in speaking such words to you,” Quorum replied, not incorrectly. “What I am advising is patience. Let her continue working in the shadows, sowing the seeds of her own destruction. There are no warrants for Hephaestus, currently. In time, thinking she’s slipped our notice, chances are strong she’ll take larger risks. Once there is a crime Hephaestus has committed, one significant enough to weaken the public’s approval and her own support within the AHC, then drawing a link between the villain and Tori could produce the results you’re after. Move too soon, lose the chance before it’s ripe. Not to mention, we don’t need the guild angry right now.”

Professor Quantum had been looking over the same reports, and the data was almost undeniable. Between the guild’s threat, Lodestar’s showy battle, and the AHC’s exceptional response to the alien invasion, crime was trending down once more. Even the misconduct still being committed was generally more low-key—the New Science Sentries had run down the first bank robbers of the week earlier that day. Peace was good. It kept the AHC looking effective and made the public more docile, easier to manage. The current situation was tenuous; tipping the guild to retribution could indeed cause more harm than momentary vengeance would be worth.

“Very well. I’ll wait for a better opportunity to strike with her identity. Until then, I’ll have to busy myself by checking each and every one of her devices for the slightest violation of federal defense statutes. Perhaps we can get them all recalled.” Hitting his keyboard without delay, Professor Quantum pulled up Indigo Technologies’ website, now with Tori’s face and new product line splashed across the front page. A few clicks, and suddenly, a distinct frown settled on the usually distinguished face.

“Something wrong?” Quorum asked.

While still professional, it was impossible to miss the terse annoyance sliding through Professor Quantum’s voice. “It seems the launch announcement struck a chord. There’s already a two week backorder.”



The guild was bustling. Tori had no sooner walked up from the teleportation chamber than she nearly collided with Gork, who pivoted her tremendous mass with delicate grace, stepping to Tori's side at the last moment.

"Whoops, sorry," Tori quickly sputtered.

"Happens to everyone." Gork readjusted her position, revealing Stasis and Arachno Bro, who'd both been blocked by her substantial size.

Pointing up to the ceiling, Stasis gestured. "We need to get one of those office bubble-mirror thingies installed there, make it easier to see who is coming from every angle. Also, going to need a high-five from Hephaestus over here. Caught your commercial this afternoon and *loved* it. 'Save ourselves,' that's going to piss the capes right off."

Tori accommodated the high-five, hitting one with Arachno Bro as well when he lifted one of his several arms, the others largely encumbered with a large metal case. It was somewhat off-putting, hearing her villain name bandied about like that, but then, she did generally use the official nomenclature for everyone aside from Ivan or the other rookies. It was part of guild protocol, though not the code specifically, which made enforcement far more voluntary among the ranks.

"Thanks. I tried to walk the line and not seem like I was coming after them. Figured that would bring down more heat than we wanted." To say nothing of how it would impact the friends she had in that organization, hearing her speak those words. In the end, Tori had found her peace with the marketing strategy in the simple facts of the matter: everything she'd said was true. The AHC *had* failed to save her, because they *couldn't* be everywhere at once. Beyond that, Tori sincerely did believe her inventions could help others from ending up in the same situation. If the capes had a real problem with the fact that they weren't able to protect everyone, then maybe they should take it as a sign to step up their game.

Gork gave her a slow, unmissable nod. "Doc wouldn't let you cross any lines. With apologies, we have a facility appointment to keep."

"That's right!" Stasis slapped the metal box in Arachno Bro's arms, causing an unexpectedly harmonic note to ring out. "We hired the Bytes to play around with some of the Wrexwren tech so handily left on their corpses—need a place with special shielding to test this out."

“Gonna be loud,” Arachno Bro added, adjusting his many-armed grip to ensure the device was perfectly snug. He was putting in enough effort to make Tori wonder what would happen if it was dropped, and how close she should really be standing.

With a wave, Tori opted to take the graceful exit they’d presented. “Have fun! I’m off to go do some tinkering myself.”

The trio headed out, barely missing getting run into by Pod Person and Killcitate as they emerged from the teleportation chamber, proving that Stasis was indeed right about the need for a bubble-mirror. Tori went another way, winding her way along the exterior path even though there were more direct routes inside.

It was startling to realize how much the island had changed just since its unveiling. New buildings were added to the town, a fresh green bubbling pit of unknown goop had appeared to the north, and it appeared that some sort of trees with faces were beginning to dot the nearest shoreline. The rest of the guild had been busy with their own activities and projects, most of which were likely even more bizarre than her own. Perhaps it was time to start spending more time around her fellow villains. The bonds formed here wouldn’t necessarily be any less complicated, but at least they’d be on the same side. Unless another insurrection formed, anyway.

Rounding a corner, Tori caught sight of Lance and Warren, or maybe Pest Control and Glyph. She needed to start thinking of them in their villainous roles with or without the costumes, but it wasn’t as if the other guild members weren’t familiar with one another. Maybe she’d just ask if they cared; sometimes, there were upsides to a reputation for bluntness.

The duo were part of a quartet hauling a giant red cube lashed onto a hefty cart, with one person manning each corner, shoving it along. Both offered a sweaty wave, forgoing verbal greetings due to their gulping breaths. Tori walked a bit further and found herself looking at an identical cube, only this one was being pushed by a single meaty hand belonging to Thuggernaut.

“Looky here, we got ourselves a celebrity.” Johnny Three Dicks poked his head around the side, making no pretense that he’d been in any way helping with the task. “What’s the going rate on one of those handbags paired with your signature?”

“I’m going to shoot straight with you, Johnny: you don’t have the shoulders to pull off that model.”

He clutched his chest, reeling back as if struck. “I like the attack, but you’ll have to pick a target other than these perfect shoulders if you want to land a blow. Besides, the design is a bit too splashy for me. I like clean lines. I was going to sell the thing online—you do know there’s already a backorder, right?”

“What Johnny means is congratulations on your new endeavor. It sounds like it’s already been very successful,” Thuggernaut stepped in to add.

The eye roll of Johnny Three Dicks was so perfect, it very well might have qualified as a superpower in itself. “Spoilsport. Anyway, nice to see you, but we’ve got to get these... materials to... a place or something will... are meltsplotions officially a thing? Can’t remember how the voting went.”

“We’re on a schedule. Good to see you, Tori, and congratulations from me, as well.” Thuggernaut resumed pushing the block, which had darkened slightly in hue, unless Tori was mistaken. She gave them a wide berth to head past her.

Watching the odd pair wander down the slope, Tori momentarily marveled at how normal the whole exchange had felt. Less than a year with these maniacs, and she was already getting accustomed to the madness. Craving it, at times, especially when normal life was fraught with more complex problems. Dealing with a meta-suit that wasn’t strong enough: simple. Start upgrading one piece at a time until one reached the desire level. It was people who made things complicated.

On her phone, an unanswered text from Donald lingered. A simple, short message: “Saw the commercial, congratulations on starting your new business. Let me know if you want to go celebrate.” She’d implied the entire enterprise he was devoting his life to wasn’t adequately doing its job, and he’d responded with an olive branch. That was the trouble with capes—they took the higher path, which made her feel all the more shitty about the slight. Were they just going to ignore it? Because her gut said the rest of Cyber Geek’s team might have different words the next time they all hung out. She didn’t know what to say back, which was why the message lingered, every passing minute potentially making the reply all the more awkward.

Suddenly looking around, Tori realized she’d taken a wrong turn. Instead of her initial destination, she’d veered off toward the council offices, where one might find Pseudonym when he was around. Of course,

Ivan didn't have an express reason to be here, so he wouldn't be. Tori spun around, absolutely secure in that knowledge right up until she nearly collided with Ivan's elbow.

He didn't dodge, merely vanished and reappeared in a different point. Sometimes, she forgot he could do short-range teleports at will—one more talent piled atop so many others. If she wanted to climb into that league, the world where people like Alfred Settler couldn't make her feel powerless, then there was very long trek ahead, and today was only one step of countless.

"Didn't expect to see you here," Ivan greeted, stealing her own line quite effectively. "Don't you want to go out and celebrate the new endeavor? I imagined Beverly would have put together an enjoyable outing for you all."

"Fancy dinner and unfancy drinks at some swanky place uptown." Tori was already annoyed by the dress code, but it wasn't as if she hadn't gotten accustomed to office attire at Vendallia; she could certainly muddle through for a high-end meal. "It's on Indigo's dime, at least. Now that I'm a public figure, Wade wants me seen around town more, flaunting the merchandise."

"Making yourself a target for anyone who wants to give them a test," Ivan pointed out.

The idea had occurred to Tori, and she responded with a mild shrug. "I was a target before, I'm still a target now. The difference is, if the AHC lets me get attacked, they give me a chance to show off while also proving that they can't always be there. The smart money is I'm going to be very protected by the superheroes until they figure out a countermove."

"Which means it will be dangerous to act as Hephaestus." Lifting his hands, Ivan gestured around them to the villainous volcano lair in which they stood. "Part of why I thought you might take a little time to lay low. There are a lot more eyes on Tori Rivas than there once were."

"But only a fraction of the ones on people like Wade Wyatt," she countered. "You are sort of half-right. I'm planning to lay low on the villain stuff for a while. The suit is due for an overhaul. Between everything I've learned and the new resources I've got access to, it no longer represents my best efforts. Doing a new build right takes time, so Hephaestus can take a breather while Tori gets her empire running."

Ivan let out a half-sigh, half-chuckle as he shook his head. "It's my own fault for expecting anything less. I'll let you get to it then."

He started to step past her, but Tori shifted her weight to block him. Despite the fact that he'd moments ago proven that she was no obstacle, Ivan still allowed her to halt his progress. "Hang on there, bucko, what are you doing here? There's no council meeting I'm aware of, not with Gork and Stasis on some weird weapons test, and no pressing emergencies to handle. That tends to be all that draws you to this place."

It was bizarre, seeing Ivan look uncertain, like watching a mountain crack a joke. He shifted back slightly, scratching under his chin. "In truth... I was a bit bored. The kids are with their mom, no Starscouts work to do, and even the office is still closed until next week." Although Ivan didn't mention the other friend he might have wanted to spend time with, Tori already knew things were tense with Helen; no need to rub salt in the wound. "I thought perhaps there might be tasks to do around here, get ahead of things for a change."

Whether or not it was wise for Ivan to spend more time here, Tori couldn't be sure. He clearly needed to keep himself busy, and being around friends was a good move in rough times, but this place had a way of drawing people deeper in. Ivan himself had been the one to warn her about that. Still, if anyone could handle the balance, it was likely to be one of the guild's own founders. There were surely better places to direct her concern.

"You know I'm not going to be coming into the office anymore, right?" Tori had already been transferred off Vendallia's payroll—though since it was an Indigo Technologies subsidy, she was technically getting heavily promoted rather than changing companies.

Ivan nodded. As her manager and former mentor, Wade had probably looped Ivan in before even she got the final confirmations. "I may never find a more competent, or surly, assistant."

"Oh, you absolutely will not," Tori agreed. "My point was that I'm glad you'll be around here, since I won't see you as much in the outside world. Probably still going to need a lot of advice, now that I'm a small-time celebrity on top of being one of the world's most promising new supervillains."

The lifted eyebrow of skepticism was much more akin to the Ivan expression Tori was used to, and she even took some comfort in the mild incredulity of his tone. "Decided on that title for yourself?"

"I stood against one of Professor Quantum's old nemeses and killed a crook with a much grander reputation than my own. If any of the other

newbies can top that, they're welcome to claim the title for themselves."

"They can't." Ivan's words were praise, yet the ones that followed were tinged with warning. "For now."

"Like I said, I'm already in the process of making sure I don't fall behind the pack." Tori checked her watch, realizing that all these delays had put her behind schedule, and she did *not* want to make Beverly late. Her roommate could be a tad tyrannical about staying on time—at least when it was something Beverly wanted to do. "On that note, better hustle. Let's do a dinner around here next week, though. I heard Scrap-Rabble opened a spot on the island with food like no one has ever tasted before."

A momentary look of mock-fear washed over Ivan's face. "Knowing Scrap-Rabble, that could encompass a great many options indeed." The pseudo-terror was fast replaced by a genuine smile. "I'll look forward to it."

They broke apart on that note, Tori wasting no more time on winding paths. All that slowed her pace was a short text reply to Donald reading: "Love to. I'll call you tomorrow and we can talk schedule." No sense in having a mentor if she wasn't going to learn from him, and Ivan was a prime example on the importance of balance. Maybe staying friends with someone on the other side would prove to be impossible long-term; however, she still wanted to try. Aside from everything she'd gone through with some of the capes, having bonds outside the guild would keep her from slipping in too deep as well—something important to keep in mind while laying low.

That done, she made as direct a line as possible to her guild laboratory, now hers long-term thanks to the deal with Wade. He'd comped her a year for free, after which, they'd revisit the issue and see if the space still suited her needs. By the time she needed to pay actual rental rates, money from the venture would be rolling in, though most of it was already earmarked for meta-suit development.

Finally making her way inside, Tori went straight to the reason she'd popped in for a visit: her new material was ready. She powered up the huge machine carefully, checking to see that everything had executed as programmed before opening the release chamber. Considering the unknown substance she'd been working with, there was a chance her creation could be toxic, if not outright destructive.

Resting atop a large podium ten feet away, suspended in a miniature gravitational field, was the bony finger of Alfred Settler. Even disconnected

from the main body, it was corrosive—the damn thing had eaten through nearly all of her suit’s hidden compartments by the time she got it back to the apartment lab, and rigging up transport to the guild had taken half a day. From there had come the material scans, trying to figure out precisely what this nigh-indestructible substance was made from, and how much could be replicated.

Several of the elements the scanner found were totally foreign, unlike anything Tori had ever seen. Others were rarer, certain trace meta-minerals like erlestrite and cadinphode that were formed by exposing more common materials to meta-elements, such as setlium. Or vernium, apparently, since Alfred’s own internal energy must have formed them in his body. Those would be integrated in later versions, when Tori had the cash to spare.

Right now, she’d found a hopefully stable build at around a seventy percent structural match. Replacing the missing elements had been the hardest part; up until today, every attempt had resulted in a pile of sludge, at best. Getting an alert that one of the sequences had produced something viable was all it took to send her rushing back to the guild.

Hitting the final buttons, a section of the large machine spun away from the wall, revealing a tightly sealed chamber. After a few seconds and some loud clangs, the door began to release its locks before slowly swinging open. Tori waited as the soft hiss of smoke cleared, showing her a rectangular hunk of metal. All readings indicated it was non-corrosive, but she still tapped it gently with a pinky finger, waiting for any telltale burn or tingle. Nothing: only cold metal, though Tori wondered if it shouldn’t be a tad colder. Trusting her instruments, she lifted the material up, bringing it out into the bright lights of the laboratory.

“Guess it’s a good thing my suit was already black.” She’d anticipated as much, given the coloration of the source material, but this was a step further than expected. More than dark, it absorbed a higher amount of light than anything she’d seen short of specialized cloaking fabrics. Handy for working at night, she supposed.

Setting the material against a far wall, Tori headed over to a table, where the remains of her meta-suit were splayed out. A few bits would be salvaged for version number two; however, most of it was going to need to be rebuilt from the ground up. She was planning to do cosmetic repairs on this one, even if it was getting retired, then see about procuring a glass case



for display. Just because it was time to move on didn't mean she wasn't proud of where she'd started.

From the table, Tori plucked her still-functioning gauntlet, the only piece of the suit to already receive full repairs. As the strongest weapon she had, it was also the best option for testing her new metal. Alfred had taken this kind of shot without missing a step, and soon, she'd be able to do the same. Because that was the danger in fighting a thief and letting them live. A good one never walked away entirely empty-handed.

Tapping the side of her laptop to wake it up, Tori clicked on the recording program and activated various scanners. The silver lining to a week of failed attempts, she'd had plenty of time to prep for once something stable came along. "Hephaestus Version Two, Settler Metal Test Number One." Flexing the gauntlet, she fueled it with power, flames cascading off her hidden hand and into the system. Without the helmet on, there was no indicator signal—she'd just used the weapons enough to learn the timing. Bit by bit, the energy level climbed as Tori got herself into position, drawing a direct line on the square of metal waiting across the room. By the time she was ready, so was the gauntlet, and she saw no reason to keep Beverly waiting with needless delays.

"Let's see just how tough I'm going to be."



With EMTs keeping the driver calm and his car set safely back on the ground, Lodestar was preparing to leave. There wasn't any crime to record, just a tired driver on a mountain road who'd tried too sharp of a turn. Lucky for him, Lodestar was flying the skies.

She'd been doing that quite a few times over the past week—whenever a certain young woman named Penelope was otherwise occupied, in fact. It was getting excessive, and she knew it, but for the moment, it was nice to have control over some part of her life. As Lodestar, she could always make a difference, always be of use, always know the right path forward. It was the human side where things got muddled. Yet that same uncertainty and confusion were what made it essential. Humans weren't sure of every move they made—losing that would mean losing a piece of what kept her... Helen.

A step down a path she was determined to avoid for as long as absolutely possible.

Before she could take to the skies, a figure appeared next to her. If the sudden emergence from nowhere and the dirty overcoat hadn't tipped her off, the kaleidoscope eyes would have. Nexus was a thorn that couldn't be plucked, not permanently. Beating him didn't matter. He always came back, the same as before. Lodestar decided to open politely tonight. She didn't want there to be any more conflict than necessary, especially given the scales of destruction Nexus could operate on.

"Out for an evening stroll?"

"Countless," he agreed. "Though only the one with you. This you, anyway. Others who wear the name, or the power, there are scant few worth watching. This world is special, however."

"I'm already aware that we have multiple Singulars, just like I know that I'm not one of them. What else can I help you with?"

He stalked around the grass at the road's side, looking with eyes that saw far more than even his most cryptic ramblings went on. It would be easy to dismiss Nexus, as many had early on, except that he constantly knew more than anyone should. Not always accurate information, but often enough that he couldn't be fully ignored, no matter how much smarter a tactic that might be. "You can heed my warning: you need to be more careful. I have seen what happens when a Lodestar dies, and do not wish for a world as interesting as this one to share the same fate."

Something in her, a piece of human fear long left dormant, stirred slightly. "Lodestars don't die. You can get rid of the person, not the power. Basically every villain I went against with any multiverse access hunted for weaknesses, and the results always came back the same."

"Ah, yes, no worlds where a Lodestar has fallen. But that doesn't mean such worlds didn't exist. I saw it happen, in a place many degrees separated from your universe, yet you wouldn't find entirely unfamiliar. Another world with multiple Singulars, such a pleasure to watch unfold. When they decided to use their abilities in tandem, I expected the same result as you, but to my surprise, they succeeded at the seemingly impossible task. Combining talents found solely in their world, the trio managed to slay their version of Lodestar. It was such a battle, the very planet shook by the end. I was enraptured at the pageantry. Then, it ended."

“That’s it? In a different corner of the multiverse, somebody allegedly killed a Lodestar, and you were so concerned that it seemed prudent to give me a warning?” Was he playing at something? Madness didn’t mean Nexus couldn’t be cunning. Perhaps this was part of a larger plan.

Something like a sad cackle split from Nexus’s lips as he stared at her with those shattered eyes. “There are plenty like you to watch, same story of self-denial and sadness echoed over and over. But this world has Singulars which make it fascinating, because their presence renders everything harder to predict, yet also means you might be killable here. That is why I came to give my warning. I do not want to see this world share the same fate.”

Thinking back on Nexus’s exact words, Lodestar caught a turn of phrase she’d initially missed, and suddenly, she felt as nauseated as if she’d been using super-speed for too long. “Nexus, when you say *it* ended, you do mean the fight, don’t you?”

Reaching into the roadside grass, Nexus tore up a handful, then blew it into the wind, each piece drifting over the mountain’s edge. “Gone, in a matter of moments. One light after another simply faded away, an entire universe collapsed into nothingness. Some of me barely made out it; some didn’t at all. I felt it to the end, the crushing obliteration. That power you wield may well be each universe’s greatest defense, but in balance, it also represents a critical weakness. No one can find a universe where Lodestar has died, because to kill a Lodestar is to end that universe. They do not leave remains, only emptiness.”

It was an absolutely lunatic statement—except deep down, part of Helen always knew there *had* to be a cost. That was the way things worked, or had worked, for a long time. Just the act of wielding the power had taken nearly everything from her, time and time again. That its existence represented a danger as well as a defense... it tracked with her understanding. However, that didn’t mean she was going to take Nexus at face value.

“I suppose it would be pointless to ask you for proof.”

“Very much so. I have none to offer, save only for the truth in my words.” He lumbered toward her, half lunge, half fall, stopping a few feet short. “Take care, Lodestar, and if I arrive to give you caution, then heed it. This world is too entertaining. I’m not yet ready for the curtain to fall.”

Then he was gone, as instantly as he’d arrived.

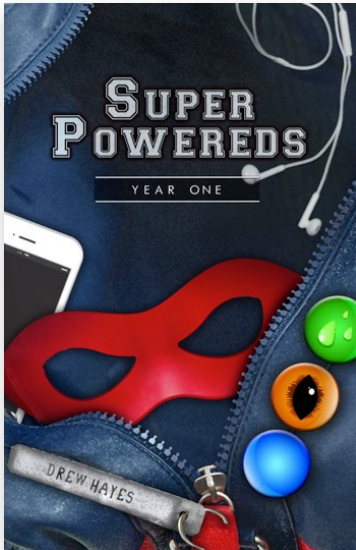
Lifting off, Lodestar flew up into the night sky, trying not to dwell too hard on his ramblings. Even if the story was true, the world he'd cited had needed multiple Singulars to accomplish the task, and by definition, none of them would be present here. Nevertheless, she already knew this was a lead that had to be chased down, as discreetly as possible. If her death would put the entire universe in danger, then that was something she'd quite like to know.

Floating up higher, she looked down upon the planet below. So messy, chaotic, flawed, and human, Helen loved this world so very much. Even now, people were making mistakes, getting into danger, looking to the heavens in the hopes of some sudden miracle to save the day. And she, of all people, was lucky enough to be able to give that help, to offer that second chance when it was needed most. Despite all it had taken from her, Lodestar enjoyed this view and everything that came with it. Even the burdens of the role were familiar weights at this point.

Shooting down from the sky, her eyes scanned about, searching for those in peril. Theoretical deaths could wait for another day. Right now, she had an entire world to keep safe. In a burst of light, Lodestar shot down into the city, flying toward a cry for help that was about to be answered in spectacular fashion.

**End of Villains' Code: Book #2**

## Other Novels by Drew Hayes





## About the Author

Drew Hayes is an author from Texas who has now found time and gumption to publish a few books. He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. You can reach Drew with questions or movie offers at [NovelistDrew@gmail.com](mailto:NovelistDrew@gmail.com) Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

Read or purchase more of his work at his site: [DrewHayesNovels.com](http://DrewHayesNovels.com)



Mise en gare de : *Le Mans, 14/10/11* Camionneur *J. Jolly*  
Mise au canal de : *Le Mans*

| Paiements    |             | Destination des Vins retirés |           |                  |                |             |           |                  |
|--------------|-------------|------------------------------|-----------|------------------|----------------|-------------|-----------|------------------|
| Date         | Montant     | Reçu                         | Payé      | Reçu de :        | En fût         | Quantité    | Reçu de : | Reçu de :        |
| <i>14/10</i> | <i>1335</i> | <i>14/10</i>                 | <i>14</i> | <i>Reçu de :</i> | <i>Le Mans</i> | <i>1335</i> | <i>14</i> | <i>Reçu de :</i> |

THE UTTERLY UNINTERESTING

*Transport* & UNADVENTUROUS TALES

OF FRED.

THE VAMPIRE ACCOUNTANT

*Transport à Lunel: 14/10*

*Drew Hayes*

*1335*





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# Dedication

*This book is dedicated to the uncool, uncoordinated, unexceptional, uncharming, uninteresting, and especially the unashamed. To everyone from the Awkwards to the Zeroes, living as the proud oddballs they are. This book is dedicated to my people.*

# A Note From The Author

I almost certainly do not know you; however, I shall assume you are a lovely person, and it is my loss for not having the opportunity to meet you. Still, I must assume you and I are connected in some way, for the works you are about to read are some selections from a journal of my memoirs. I compiled these not in the belief that the stories within are so compelling they must be told, but rather because I found my unexpected life transition to be so shockingly uneventful, at least initially. I place the blame for my aggrandized expectations squarely on the contemporary media, filling my head with the belief that a ticket to the supernatural also put one on an express train toward coolness and suave charm.

This is simply not the case. Or, at least, it was not in my case. I recorded my journeys in the hopes that, should another being find themselves utterly depressed at the humdrum personality still saddling their supernatural frame, they might find solace in knowing they are not the only one to have felt that way. Names have been changed as I deemed necessary. Given the lengthy lifespan of many people with whom I associate, there is no guarantee they will have passed on by the time this is read.

So, dear reader, whom I suspect is a wonderful person merely in need of a bit of reassurance, take comfort in my tales of uneventful blundering. One's nature is hard to change; sometimes even death is insufficient to accomplish such a task. Be assured that, while you might find yourself still more human than anticipated, you are far from the only one. You will eventually discover that under the movie stereotypes, imposed mystique, and overall inflated

expectations, each and every one of us is at least a touch more boring than our images would indicate.

And that is not a bad thing.

—Fredrick Frankford Fletcher



# A Vampire at the Reunion

## 1.

I was midway through packing when I paused to contemplate whether it was appropriate to bring the blood. I mean, sure I needed it and all, but there's always been something so garish about pulling a bag of O Negative from my little, leather luggage. I weighed the options for a few moments, pitting my desire for stylish secrecy against my nutritional needs. In the end, I forged a compromise, pouring the blood into my faux silver (obviously the real deal is off limits) flask, sealing it well, then placing it between my freshly pressed shirts.

My name is Fredrick Frankford Fletcher, and yes, that name did get me beaten up quite frequently when I was a child. For those of you who are a little slow on the uptake, I am also a vampire. It was a relatively recent life change. It happened only about one year ago. I'll spare you the gory details, but one night I was a mild mannered accountant with a heartbeat, and the next night I wasn't. Oh, I was still a mild mannered accountant, but the heartbeat was long gone. I took it well, I feel, or as well as one can handle such things. I attempted to go hunting and feed; however, while I might have been a fearful predator of the night, I still chafed at the idea of physical violence. I can't even watch slasher films without covering my eyes. After a few failed feeding fiascos left me leaning toward starvation, I opted to use a different set of my skills to secure sustenance.

John Smith, as I will call him here, was a local hospital director that had

paid me to cook his books and keep his failing enterprise above water in previous years. Generally, all criminal activity gives me ulcers, but the cause of keeping a hospital afloat allowed me to feel that the karmic scales balanced out. After my life change, we struck a new deal in which I would offer the same service each year, in exchange for the opportunity to purchase my dinners of choice from his blood supply.

The rest of my lifestyle adaptations were fairly simple. I began having files delivered to my home in the day so I could work on them at night, I refitted my refrigerator for a predominantly liquid diet, and I resumed my life as it was. I was even able to continue indulging my penchant for fine cheeses, despite what voluminous lore had told me. Without being crass, let me simply say an undead body handles normal food as a human one handles gum. While not built for nourishment, it is capable of disposing of such materials. This was far from the first discrepancy I uncovered in my cinema-based education.

Perhaps if I had any true friends or family, the transition might very well have been more difficult; however, that was not a burden with which I had been shouldered. My life was just as grey and dull as it had been before.

In a way, that was the most difficult part of my transition, going from the thrill of something new back to the dreariness of the old. I suppose a part of me had believed the Hollywood hype about vampires living (in a non-literal sense, of course) adventurous lives filled with sex, danger, and riches. My own undead experience had been . . . somewhat less thrilling. I'd spent ample time raiding the video stores in my town, and I must say I had yet to uncover any tales of vampires whose unlives continued so perfectly parallel to their days of breathing and sunshine as mine did. I would have taken great comfort in such a film. It was that nagging sense of disappointment that toiled away in my subconscious, and it was the need for something—anything really—to be different that prompted me to make such a dangerous decision.

I was going to my ten-year high school reunion. Now, I know that this must seem like an impulsive and idiotic idea, and, in truth, it was. I saw that clearly when the invitation arrived. I recognized it, analyzed it, and catalogued it in my mental filing system as I had done everything else in my

monotonous twenty-eight years on this earth. This time though, something caught on the corner of my cranial cabinet, and I saw an opportunity. Here was a chance to take a risk, albeit a small one, and do something that qualified as unsafe. Whimsical even, if one discounted my previous analyzation of the situation. Before I could talk myself out of it, I mailed my confirmation reply and booked a non-refundable ticket to my hometown of Kent, Idaho. It was only later I realized the flight was scheduled during daytime and was therefore useless to me, but the grandness of the gesture remained poignant, and I resolved to attend my reunion anyway.

Some three weeks later, as I packed up my supplies for the weekend to come, I began to wonder if other vampires felt this skittish before seeing people who knew them in life. The only other vampire I had even encountered was the one who turned me, and he was gone before I awoke. I prowled the darkness at first, hoping to find others of my kind, but after a few movies depicting the vampire political system, I started staying in more. I didn't really have the constitution for such constant subterfuge and betrayal. A pleasant evening with merlot, blood, and brie worked just fine, thank you very much.

I zipped up my bag and hefted it onto my shoulder. This would have been an ordeal in itself three years ago, but with the night hours and the new allergies to garlic, silver, and sunshine came a few undeniable perks. Eternal life was pleasant enough I suppose, though I'd become concerned about what I would do once I finished viewing every movie in the rental store. At least I might be around long enough to truly enjoy the appreciation of my smarter financial investments. The enhanced strength, durability, and dexterity were all quite nice, though. I was more than a minor klutz in my human days, so it was an enjoyable change to walk around without injuring myself.

After locking my door and setting my alarms, I stepped into the new night air. It was crisp with the chill of late October. Admittedly a strange time for a high school reunion, but Kent was a farming community. The fall holidays were close to harvest time, and therefore the heaviest celebrated. For those of you fortunate enough to not understand that reference, harvest time is

one of the hardest working periods on a farm. A night off is not just reason to celebrate; it is reason to celebrate to the umpteenth degree. Since Thanksgiving is spent with family, Kent will often hold its reunions on or around Halloween. This year was my class's turn, and as Halloween fell on a Saturday, our event was planned for the night of the pumpkin-themed holiday. As a real live (again, only in a matter of speaking) vampire would be in attendance, I felt this was particularly appropriate. Even if I was the only one who would know it.

I loaded the leather suitcase into the back of my grey hybrid. I had always tried to be eco-conscious, but realizing I could actually live to be affected by eventual environmental disasters had doubled my efforts. Once the suitcase was secured, I placed a travel mug of blood into the cup holder and buckled myself in as well. I would have to drive through the night to make it to my hotel in time, but that hadn't been an issue for over a year. If I were still human, I would have taken a deep breath to steel myself for the expected adventure ahead. Since I was not, I checked my mirrors and turned on my signal, pulling into the road with both hands firmly on the wheel.

## 2.

I made it to the hotel approximately an hour before the sun would crest the western horizon. Almanacs were never something I gave much thought to before my change. Now they were like credit cards; I never went anywhere without one.

Check-in was a simple process. An advantage of my timing was that none of the other alumni were entering at that time. They had either come earlier or would be showing up during the day. That was well and good for me; I had neither desire nor intention of seeing them outside of the controlled environment that the reunion would offer. Less chance of anyone remembering favorite old games of beating me up or throwing me naked into the girl's locker room. Just the memories were giving me a stress headache, if I were still susceptible to them.

I received my key packet from a girl working the front counter and ventured up to my room. Once there I opened my suitcase and pulled out my safety materials. I had several rolls of tinfoil and tape. It took me only twenty minutes to seal off every possible venue the sun might utilize to enter my room. That was one skill sheer survival had forced me to practice at length.

I gently removed my costume from the suitcase and began shaking out the obvious wrinkles. Yes, since we were having the reunion on Halloween, it had been designated a costume party. My costume was a set of scrubs and a white doctor's coat. Now, I'm sure some of you will wonder why I didn't simply throw on black clothing and bill myself as a vampire. The sad truth was that I looked precious little like an undead demon of the night. Granted,

the dying had slimmed me down and taken away my need for glasses, but I still had the same mousy brown hair, round face, and unappealing arrangement of features I'd always been cursed with. I'd already favored a pale complexion, so that difference was scarcely noticeable. My fangs only extended themselves if I was feeding, exceptionally hungry, or . . . um . . . ah . . . otherwise excited, to put it properly. It also didn't help that I almost immediately took to wearing fake glasses with similar frames after the change. It might not seem rational, but after twenty-five years, they were as much a part of my face as the eyes they stood in front of, and I couldn't bear to part with them.

All of that reasoning aside, the point of a Halloween costume is to be something you are not. Since I was a vampire, that would have been cheating. At least that's how I rationalized it to myself as I ironed my costume and hung it in the hotel closet. I did a few shirts next, making certain I would have appropriate clothing to wear on my return drive Sunday night. There was really no rush; I had gotten a week ahead on my work so that I could spend a few more days here if the desire struck me. I couldn't possibly conceive of a reason why that desire would strike me. I had left this town as fast as my awkward human legs would carry me, but it was my understanding that impulsive people were given to inclinations such as that. This weekend, if never again, I was determined to be impulsive. Or as impulsive as a vampire with four clean pairs of clothes and a four-day supply of blood can be.

I settled into the bed and turned on the television. Contrary to popular mythology, I neither sleep in a coffin, nor am I rendered powerless during the daytime. The difference between the two is that in the daytime I can sleep, which is an ability I lack under starlight. I don't have to, and in fact spent three weeks without any rest during last year's tax season; however, I am a creature of habit as much as of the night. I slept my whole life. I saw no compelling reason to change that in my undead incarnation. I switched through the channels until I was satisfied that there was nothing worth staying up for. I then set my alarm for 5 o'clock sharp and put in a wake-up call for the same time. The reunion began at 7 p.m., and sunset was at 7:17 p.m. This

way I had ample time to shower, get into my costume, and enjoy some blood before heading into the night. I didn't really need to drink every night; twice a week would serve my needs quite well. However, I have a tendency to stress eat, which caused my human form to become somewhat doughy in the first place. The effects weren't quite so negative this time. I simply increased my blood bill for the month.

I could tell the sun had risen by the time on my clock. My foil shielding had worked flawlessly, and not a speck of light leaked through. With a minor expenditure of effort, I pushed my mind away from consciousness and into what was, I assumed, the vampiric equivalent of an REM cycle.

### 3.

I must admit, my former academic colleagues were quite adept and varied in their costume conceptions. The only rules of the evening were that one could not cover one's face, which served to fuel the creative fires in fashioning a functional costume, and that a visible nametag was required all night. The latter of those two killed any sense of realism I might have felt while staring at Anne Boleyn, Elvis, or Jake Blues. My doctor garb was relatively untainted by the cheap tag. I had read the invitation carefully and therefore procured a name-badge holder that real doctors use and slipped the identifying piece of plastic inside. There are times when it pays to be careful and prepared.

As I slunk, for lack of a better word, around the cheaply decorated cafeteria, I found myself taken aback at the changes that had clearly not taken place in my fellow Kent High alumni. Near the entrance sat a fairy princess in a low cut top: Joyce Trainer, homecoming queen turned mother of four. To the human eye, she appeared a miracle, still firm, fit, and perky even after four rounds with hormones and weight gain. She was significantly less miraculous to me, since I could actually smell the plastic and Botox that riddled her body. Ah, the crux of vanity. The upside of never having good looks was that I didn't have to fear losing them with age. Pity I wasn't pretty though; then they would have kept for eternity. Although for all I know, I wouldn't have been bitten if I were good looking, so I suppose there's no sense second-guessing fate.

Brent Colter, one of many of my school-day bullies, was standing near



the refreshment table, romancing a collection of former co-eds whose names I couldn't recall. His cheap Spartan costume covered him fully, but it was tight enough that his frame was hardly obscured. His former football-player's physique had softened around the edges, but as the ladies' attention indicated, he was still a broad-shouldered, muscular man. I felt mildly disappointed; I was hoping he would devolve into full blown obesity, but I suppose ten years is a little soon to expect age to have caught up to him so severely. It dawned on me that I wouldn't be able to attend many more of these. Sooner or later someone would notice that the rest of the class was growing older, while dear Fredrick stayed frozen in his mid-twenties. Brent was clearly aging though, which was pleasant to see in my former tormentor. I was hopeful that I could visit him in the nursing home one day, and rub in that I was still young and fit while he had grown weak and decrepit. Assuming I could find time to keep track of him, of course . . . and only if I could be assured he wouldn't spill my secret to others . . . and if it wasn't during tax season.

Maybe I would just settle for a trip to dance on his grave.

The nameless clustered herd of my class was filled with people who were as much the same as they were different. Bodies had grown or shrunk with mass, and minds had been filled by knowledge or numbed by boredom, but the people under the faces were nearly the same as before. The basketball team was dressed predominantly as pimps and rowdily slapped high fives with each member to enter the gym. The chess club was in their own corner, dressed in superhero costumes that bore exceptional detail. The theater club was here and there, danced as characters I could only half recognize from famous plays and films. Amidst it all, I felt just as I had in the human days, different and set apart. I took a seat at an unoccupied table, sipping on the poorly flavored sugar water they had the gall to call punch. I should have been up and mingling, but that just wasn't me. I wasn't like these people . . . even back when I was still biologically like these people.

I was on the verge of giving the whole trip up for a bad idea when the devil sat down next to me. She was wearing a black and red corset, with black leather pants and red boots. Two horns sprouted from the blonde hair that

hung to her shoulders; red contacts obscured the brown eyes that I could still make out underneath. She was fit and sexy, not a whiff of plastic on her person, either. A vampire in the movies would have delivered the perfect opening line that conveyed mystery, power, and sex appeal.

Instead I said, “You’re supposed to be wearing a nametag.” She arched an eyebrow and stared me down for a few moments. I had begun contemplating faking a bathroom emergency to escape when she replied, “Well, I am the ultimate rebel.” I laughed a little in spite of myself. I liked rules, and they only worked if they applied to everyone, but I also liked a beautiful woman who would talk to me. Guess which one was taking precedence at that point?

“Seriously though,” I said, “how do we know who you are if you aren’t wearing a nametag?”

The devil leaned toward me, offering a more apt view down her corset in the process, and whispered conspiratorially, “And why do you want to know who I am, doctor?”

“Well . . . um . . . I suppose we might have known each other . . . back when we went to school here.”

“Did you know many women who looked like me?” she asked with a hint of a purr in her voice. All her body language indicated that she was flirting with me, but her heart rate was steady, and I didn’t smell any pheromones or hormones being released. If only I had these senses during my formative years, I could have saved myself a multitude of embarrassments when girls thought it was funny to flirt with the nerd.

I pulled my back straight and made a significant effort not to look down the appealing ravine of her corset, and then spoke. “I feel I knew far too many women like you in those days. Granted, none bore your particular physical features, but the streak of cruel humor was most notably the same. I don’t know why you are pretending to flirt with me, but I assure you that I am on to your little game. I would very much like it if you left me alone now.”

If I were still human, then my face would have been bright red from embarrassment. I expected her to be grumpy that I spoiled her fun, or fake anger at me for calling her out. The devil did neither. She threw her head back

and laughed whole heartedly. I became increasingly uncomfortable as she devolved into guffaws and then to chuckles. Finally, when her humor was little more than a low murmur in her throat, she responded.

“Well look at you, Freddy, ten years and about fifty pounds ago, you never could have stood up to a girl like that.”

I blinked a few times (another trait that is all habit and no need) before tentatively answering her. “Krystal?”

Krystal was the only female friend I had in my younger days, and, truthfully, saying “friend” is stretching it. We were both out of shape and had more caution than ambition in the social world. We didn’t really spend time together per se, but our friend group was the same, so we knew one another well enough. She had an annoying habit of nicknaming people, so I was thusly deemed “Freddy” in her eyes.

“You got it, Freddy, and in one try, too. I think I should be a little bit offended.” She smiled at me as she reached into her purse and pulled out her own name tag, sticking it in a very high-profile area on her corset.

“Wh . . . what . . . what on earth happened to you?”

“About the same as happened to you, I’m sure. Lasik for my eyes, diet and exercise for the body, just plain old growing up for the rest. You look good, by the way, very lean.”

“Thank you,” I murmured. I was glad I didn’t have blood pumping through my system anymore, otherwise I would have been so red faced my costume could have been titled “Dr. Tomato.”

“So catch me up, Freddy. How has life been? What do you do? You have a wife?” She began blathering, eschewing the calm and seductive vibe.

“Life has been . . . well, pretty boring, to be honest. I work as a CPA. No wife or girlfriend, but I do have a very robust film collection. Yourself?”

“Eh, not so far off from yours. No relationships . . . They don’t work so well with my line of work. I can’t say my life is boring, but it is more predictable than I would like sometimes. All in all not too bad though. I make a living, and that’s something to be thankful for.”

“True. So what is it that you do?”

“Ahhhh, what now?” She tripped over her words as her heart rate went up. I had just caught her off guard.

“You mentioned your job was counter to relationships, but didn’t clarify what it was. Therefore, I asked what your job was.”

“Oh. I’m a . . . cosmetologist. You wouldn’t believe the hours they make us work. No time for dates at all. Look, Freddy, I need to use the ladies’ room. I’ll be back in a few minutes,” she lied as she hustled herself off to the restroom. I turned my attention back to my glass of punch. If I had thought I wanted to leave earlier, getting recognized and ditched by one of the few people I thought of as close to a friend had undoubtedly strengthened that resolve.

I left my sad little corner and ventured to the refreshment table. Brent was still talking to two girls, one a slutty cop and one a slutty nurse, but otherwise the area was unattended. They detached themselves from him and headed toward the restroom. With the looks they were throwing back, it was not at all likely that he was being abandoned in the same fashion as me. It wasn’t even eight yet, so the party was relatively sparse. I had been led to understand that it was more fashionable to arrive later, but it was a talent I never had the inclination nor the opportunity to cultivate. After all, the few times I was invited places I was too afraid of missing things to arrive late, and I was too tired to stay when things worth seeing actually happened. I blended into the background, and no one ever remembered to invite me a second time. As I took a small block of swiss onto my plate and refilled my punch glass, I began thinking if maybe it had been better that way. At least at home I was comfortable. Being out here, with these people, I was just being reminded of all the things that I wasn’t. And alive wasn’t even the highest item on the list.

I stayed in my funk until an hour later, when the lights went out and the chaos began.

## 4.

The crowd had swollen with costumed, former students. The range and variety of outfits were actually rather fascinating. There was everything from vampires and werewolves, to pixies, to knights, to what I was 90% sure was a local fast-food chain's mascot. I had plucked up enough courage to speak to a couple of people whose names I vaguely remembered, though my attempts were not well received. There had been a select few I would have been comfortable talking with, but, unfortunately, aside from Krystal and me, none of the formerly socially outcast individuals had elected to attend. I had kept an eye (and perhaps a nose) out for Krystal; however, she seemed to have utterly vanished since her trip to the ladies' room. I was standing by the gym's bleachers, fighting with myself on whether staying or leaving would be more cowardly, when the power in the building suddenly died.

At first there was an awkward chuckle that rippled through the attendance. Power outages happen, and when they do, it is human nature to assume that someone is already on the problem fixing it. I scarcely even noticed. I didn't need light to see anyway. After a few minutes, some of the more responsible members of my former class elected to open the doors up and let in some light from outside. That was their intention, anyway. I heard the rattling from the door frame and recognized the sound even before the shout of clarification accompanied it.

"Hey . . . Hey! This isn't funny. Somebody locked us in!"

I was remarking in my mind how much more at ease I felt when everyone was as invisible as me, when the second scream tore through the party, this

one much bloodier than the original. Everyone turned in the direction of the yell, but I'd bet I was the only one who could actually see a pudgy, brunette mummy being pulled into the hallway. I was sure I was the only one who could smell the sweet, tangy blood pouring across her sadly appropriate bandages. Odds were good I was *still* the only one who could make out the form of a hulking creature in the doorframe that was doing the dragging. All of this told me quite clearly that being at this party was no longer a minor risk. In that moment, I decided to do what any intelligent vampire would do in my position.

I ran like hell. Admittedly, I jumped the gun before the rest of the revelers, but they had only heard a horrific scream. I had seen what caused it. They joined in a few seconds later, though. Say what you will about humans; they have a flight-or-fight instinct that is surprisingly well developed. They didn't even know what was going on, and they were making the right move.

Or were they? I slowed my sprint to the door and moved toward the side of the wall. The rest of the crowd assaulted every exit, only to find each one reinforced and wrapped in chains on the outside. I could have ripped them down if it came to it, but then I would have had to explain how I did it once we were outside. Being hunted as a monster by a group of angry townsfolk wasn't much better than the situation I was already in, so that was a last resort.

There were two other ways out of the gym. Doors that led into the school were at the north and south ends. Since the scream had come from the north end, everyone began stampeding toward the south exit. As I watched them, I was struck by how much they resembled livestock being herded into a chute. That thought solidified my decision. No way was I leaving with the crowd. I could just wait until they all left and then rip open a door and be on my merry way. I know it seems like I was being a coward, but let's be fair. These were hardly people I had fuzzy feelings toward, and dying scared me quite a bit more since I had already done it once.

I was watching them stumble over ill-conceived costume decisions as they fumbled in the dark, when something caught my eye. There was a

commentator's box near the top of the gym. It had a catwalk and opened into the 2<sup>nd</sup> floor of the school. With all the bleachers pulled out, it would be easy enough to access; however, since they were shoved into the wall, it would be nearly impossible to reach from here. That is, assuming one didn't have enhanced physical abilities and a fear that served as an exceptional motivator. It was pitch dark, and no one was looking at me anyway.

I scaled the bleacher wall in under a minute. If anyone noticed sounds from the room behind them, they opted not to try and peer into the darkness, but rather to just escape faster. The door on the side of the commentator's box was unlocked, so I slipped in without needing to break off the handle. From here it would be an easy journey to a balcony to the outside where I could hop down to my car and to safety. I was halfway through the small cube when a surprising scent caressed my nostrils. Leather, human, sweat—and recent familiarity. Krystal. Now that I was listening, I could hear her heartbeat as well. She was bound and gagged, taped under the table where the commentators would normally sit.

I reached for her very quickly. Helping a former friend was all well and good, but I still needed to get the hell out of there. She immediately began thrashing against her bonds and screaming into her gag. I'd forgotten I was the only one of us who could see in the dark.

"Krystal, calm down. It's Fred. Something very strange is happening, and I'm trying to get you out of here." She stopped struggling immediately and looked in my direction with gratitude and what seemed like a bit of embarrassment. I dismounted her from the table's underside with relative ease. The tape was a more gradual process, but once I freed her arms, she was able to help the escape effort.

"What happened to you?" I asked as she spit the last fibers of her gag from her mouth.

"I got ambushed in the bathroom. Stupid bitches."

"Ambushed? By whom? Why would they do that? What the hell is going on? Do you know why the power's out?" My frustration at the evening's sudden turn from unenjoyable to potentially deadly apparently decided to

manifest itself in the form of verbal diarrhea. Under my articulated assault, Krystal's heart rate spiked again, then subsided. Her face took on a resigned look. Much as it had when we were kids and she was on a diet. She might not like what she was about to do, but she would do it anyway.

"Okay, Freddy, slow down. I owe you a little bit of truth for helping me out tonight. I gotta keep it brief; this isn't exactly the safest area to hide since it's the first place anyone who wants me will look."

"That's fair." In reality her point made me far less concerned with my own ignorance of the situation and more interested in extricating myself from it. However, I was genuinely curious, and Krystal was still wearing her corset. Besides, if push came to shove, I would probably be okay. Vampires can really haul some ass when needed.

"To begin with, I'm sorry I flaked out when you asked me about my job."

"It's okay, Krystal."

"Nah, it isn't. You're a sweet guy, Freddy, and I know how personally you take that kind of stuff. See, I didn't actually come here planning to talk with anyone tonight, but when I saw you sitting by your lonesome, I couldn't help myself. Then you caught me off guard with the job thing, and I didn't have a lie prepared."

"So, why did you come tonight if you weren't going to talk with anyone?" As I asked my question, she began rooting around the room blindly, groping under chairs and in cabinets.

"I came here on assignment for work."

"Will you elaborate this time?"

She let out a heavy sigh. "Damnit, Freddy, this is the kinda shit I was specifically trying to avoid. Look, I'll tell you what I do, but you won't believe me." She had finished the obvious places and began checking behind speakers and electronic equipment.

"Given that I just found you bound and gagged, my mind is somewhat more receptive than it might normally be."

"Well, then, here's the deal," Krystal said as she sat down next to me. "Everything you think you know about monsters is a lie. Ghouls, ghosts,



werewolves, all of them and more are real and hiding out behind the scenes in our world. Officially they are known as ‘parahumans,’ and part of my job is to hunt down the ones that get out of hand. I work for an agency without an official name or address. I’m here because we learned that some local werewolves planned on using tonight as an all-you-can-eat buffet. You know, you can call me crazy at any point here, and I’ll shut up.”

“What about vampires?” I asked. From the look on her face, that was hardly the response she was expecting.

“Um, yeah. Vampires are real, too. They’re hard as shit to root out, though, and major league badasses to boot. Only the top operatives deal with those things.”

“I see,” I said. I was a little relieved. If they had thought that highly of vampires, it was unlikely I’d have to deal with this “agency” anytime soon.

“I gotta tell you here, Freddy. You’re taking this a hell of a lot better than I was expecting,” Krystal said, before resuming her hand-guided search around the room.

“It’s been an interesting few years. Besides, as I said, finding you stuffed under a table lends some credence to your story. What are you looking for anyway?”

“My purse. I need my gun and my silver bullets. I thought I heard them put them in here somewhere, but I didn’t really have a great vantage point, so I might be wrong.”

I could feel my skin prickle at the mention of silver. Still, if she was going to gun down several monsters, then she would need her weapon. I smelled carefully, trying to ignore her immediate scent. I needed to track the same smell, but a version that was muddled and fading. That would lead me to any objects that had spent long amounts of time around her, such as her purse. It took me only a few seconds to find it; the kidnappers had oh-so-cleverly put it inside one of the speakers. I got up to pull the speaker open, but a power cord had entangled my foot. So, instead I went crashing into it head first.

“Shit!” Krystal whisper-shouted. “Are you okay?”

“Fine. Just fine. Cheap plastic, and all that. Also, I think I found your purse.” I handed it to her as I pulled myself up and extricated my leg from the diabolical power cord.

“Awesome! You still rock, Freddy.” She pulled a handgun out from the purse, followed by a series of clips exuding a smell that made my stomach start churning. She tucked all that into her pants, then pulled out what appeared to be a pair of swimmer’s goggles with electronics glued to them. She adjusted the band and slipped them over her eyes. When she turned to me and waved, the gears clicked in my head, and I realized she was wearing extremely compact night vision goggles. I also realized I should probably pretend to be far less capable of seeing in darkness than I really was.

“Thanks for the assist, Freddy. You literally saved some lives tonight. Once this is all said and done, we should get lunch or something before we head home.”

“Sounds like a pleasant way to spend an afternoon.”

“Yeah.” She went to the door that led into the school’s second floor, pressing her ear against it and keeping her gun at the ready. Her free hand crept down to the knob, turning it slowly until it came to an abrupt stop. “Damn, it’s still locked.” Her head flicked toward me for a moment. Then she took a knee and produced a set of picks from her hair. In seconds she had the lock disabled and resumed her careful opening of the door. She pulled it open inch by inch, minimizing the sound and getting a full view of the hallway. After stepping out to make sure it was clear, she walked over to me.

“Okay, Freddy, listen close. The nearest balcony to here is to your right. Once you walk out the door, go right till you hit a wall, and then go to the left. Trace your hand along the wall on your right, and when you feel the third door, open it. It should be a classroom with a big window and door to an outside balcony. I know it will hurt, but you need to jump off that balcony and run to your car. Roll with the landing if you can—it will minimize chances you’ll break something. You got all that?”

“I believe I can handle it.”

“Good. One last thing.” She pushed a stiff, smooth rectangle into my

hand. “That’s my card with my cell number. Give me a call when you’re safe, and let me know you lived through this. Okay?”

“I certainly will,” I lied.

She got up and headed back to the door. Gun in front she exited, pausing only to look at me once more. I remembered that I wasn’t supposed to be able to see those looks, and then that made them all the more curious. At any rate, I was ready to get out of here. Krystal had handed me an exit, and I had no inclination to let that information go to waste. I’m sure a Hollywood vampire would have run after her, swept her into his arms, and handled all the villains himself. That, however, was not me. All I wanted to do was get back to my hotel room safely and relax.

Werewolves, real or not, most definitely fell into the realm of someone else’s problem.

## 5.

Staring down from my hiding place on the balcony, I discovered that the werewolves fell squarely into the realm of my problem. There were three of them patrolling the parking lot, three sedan-sized mounds of fur and muscle, with teeth that looked as though they could tear through metal. They were staying low among the vehicles, visible only from a higher vantage point. So far two separate groups of humans had made it to the parking lot, only to be struck down before they could get near their cars. The werewolves weren't killing yet, just subduing. Every so often a howl would echo from the school's interior, and the sentries would perk their ears. I could only guess at what messages were being conveyed.

I was lying flat on the balcony, my eyes watching the scene from a nearby window's reflection. None of the options placed before me were too appealing. I could either vault the balcony and make a run for it, hope to stay here until the werewolves moved on, or sneak back into the school. The problems were that I didn't know if I could outrun these things. If I stayed here till sunup, I'd be dead anyway, and from the sounds inside, it seemed like other werewolves were working their way through the building. Once they caught my scent, I'd have no hope of hiding out. The heavy padding that arose from down the hall, behind my hiding spot, made my decision for me. At least with a running sprint, I'd have the advantage of surprise.

I shot upward and leapt the balcony's railing in a single motion. On pure instinct I rolled with the landing, and promptly cursed myself for wasting time instead of hitting the ground running. I recovered quickly and took off

through the lot. I kept my speed in human limits to start with. I might only get one chance to outrun or maneuver these things, and I didn't want to give them any warning of what I could really do.

A pair of werewolves rushed out from the parking lot's entrance, trying to pincer me from both sides. They angled themselves diagonally, blocking the lanes to the left and right, and prepared to charge if I tried to go around them. I must admit; these things were far smarter than mere animals. The only options they had left me were to fruitlessly try to dodge and get torn to pieces, or to run smack into the grill of a pickup truck in front of me.

I chose the latter. I jumped atop the truck and over its roof without breaking stride. If you have never been fortunate enough to see a look of utter surprise race across a werewolf's face, I highly recommend you do so. My furry foes were forced to backpedal and change directions, getting into the rows on either side of me. No doubt they expected me to disembark from the truck and give them a chase on the ground. Their hopes were dashed when I vaulted directly from the truck onto the next car in line and kept running. Going from car to car would have been hard for humans, but not impossible. They would have to be exceptionally well balanced and in excellent shape to use the strategy at a full run, though. In life I was neither of those things; however, I was rather happily enjoying my advantage at that moment.

The chase continued across several lanes of parked cars. A few times one of my pursuers would try to mount a vehicle in hopes of overtaking me on higher ground, but their vast size and weight always made the footing unstable. They contented themselves to snapping at my heels, never quite snaring me but doing considerable damage to the metal beneath my feet. I sincerely hoped everyone who made it out of here was insured. Speed wise they were able to keep pace with me, unfortunately. The upside was that I could move faster than this if I needed, and while they would tire out eventually, I was under no such limitations. I allowed a cautious amount of optimism to creep over me. Once I tuckered these two out, I could make an earnest break for my car and escape. It seemed like I was going to be okay.

In keeping with the ways of the universe, it was at that moment I was run

over by a third werewolf. I was so preoccupied with handling the two below me I had forgotten there was another to watch for. He slammed into me from his hiding place in the bed of a nearby truck and hurled me from my position. I crunched into a motorcycle a few yards away and lay there. A hit like that would have easily incapacitated a human, and as far as these things knew, that's what I was.

The one who hit me, a grey beast whose size seemed closer to the bear family than the wolf one, came over to me and sniffed. I kept myself still as death, which is ironically still quite difficult for me. Just because my body doesn't have to move doesn't mean my consciousness doesn't want to. The only concession I made was to move my chest up and down, making sure they all knew I was still "breathing." A sharp tug on my leg let me know they were dragging me to wherever they had taken the others. I kept my eyes closed and my false breathing steady.

My therapist says I have confrontation issues. He's not wrong. At least he better not be at his prices. As I lay there, being dragged toward who knows what, my thoughts were not on fighting my way free or saving the rest of the class. My mind was in my apartment in Winslow, Colorado, all those miles away, fervently trying to think of a way back there.

## 6.

By the time I felt like it was safe to “wake up,” I had been blindfolded and tied to a metal bar in, of all places, the gym. I couldn’t see anything through my black-fabric blindness, but I could smell the fear and blood coming from all my fellow victims. It seemed like nearly all of us were here, and from the sounds of struggling, they were just as restrained as I was. Four figures were moving around freely, two of them on four feet, and two of them as bipeds. There was no talking, only barks and snarling. In the far distance, I could vaguely make out the sounds of someone drawing closer to our location. Part of me hoped Krystal was coming to help out, but part of me wished she would just see it was hopeless and leave. She had been kind to me that night, reminding me of the few people I had liked and trusted in my living days. I didn’t want to see her get killed in some pointless attempt to save us. A loud, booming voice interrupted my attempts to track the approaching figure.

“Ten years!” It echoed, “Ten years since our pack was formed, ten years in secret, ten years in silence, ten years in darkness!”

It sounded familiar. Guttural and with a canine undertone, but familiar nonetheless. It continued, “You have all come here to reunite over what you once were, while we have come to see the last you will ever be. Tonight we no longer hunt in secret! Tonight we force the world to see us and accept us for what we are! A superior species to the weak humans!”

The voice I might never have placed; however, the ego shone through crystal clear. Brent Colter. Looks like my old bully had traded up in the world.

No wonder he was still so muscular and strong. Doesn't it figure? I become an undead creature of the night, and I can't even get a date. He becomes a glorified mutt, and he manages to pull off a grand murder plot. Jerk.

"Tonight we sacrifice all these souls to our goddess, Grwlbrkgrwl [Look, I'm doing my best to be accurate here, but if you know a way to transcribe a name that's pronunciation sounds like nails in a garbage disposal, then I'd love to see it.], who will bless us with the strength to overcome all who stand against us. Then we shall spread our strength until it is the humans who hide and live in fear, and never again the True Wolves!" Howls, of what I assumed was agreement, followed Brent's speech.

The bonds holding me in place were suddenly severed, though the ones binding my hands were left in tact, as I was pulled into the air by rough, coarse hands. A tug tore away my blindfold, affording me a full view of my surroundings. The party atmosphere had been largely wrecked by the mad trample for the doors. Tables and chairs were overturned, streamers and bits of costume littered the floor, and unclaimed nametags were scattered like confetti that yearned to be identified. In the center of the room now stood a small platform, and atop it a metal framing with straps for holding appendages. The roof had been opened, and moonlight was spilling down onto the new platform, illuminating a series of blades and blunt instruments attached to it.

My fellow classmates were all bound to the bleachers, arms tied together so they had no hope of getting free. They were blindfolded as well. It made a bit of somber sense—give someone a feeling of fear, and they get passive. Let them know inescapable death is at hand, and they'll fight with every measure of strength they have.

The hands holding me in the air did indeed belong to Brent, though they were much bigger than normal. He stood below me, half in wolf form, and half in human. He was at least seven-feet tall, covered in shaggy black hair, and his face was contorted into a hideous partial muzzle. The other two werewolves from the parking lot were still in full-fuzzball mode, though the grey wolf had shifted into a form similar to Brent's. I didn't recognize who



the grey wolf was, but I'd had a voice and a personality to help me figure out Brent's identity through this morphed and furry visage. He smiled, I think, and his voice rumbled.

"Well, well, well . . . Faggy Freddy came back for the reunion, huh? I can't think of a better person to start with." With that he tossed me over his shoulder and began sauntering slowly toward what I had already come to think of as the Death Rack. He took his time, moving in a rhythmic precision that I can only assume was part of the ceremony. Panic was welling up in me, and it was looking more and more like my only chance was going to be showing my nature and making a dash. As I looked at my old classmates, though, my constant plan of flight faltered. These people weren't ones I particularly cared about; however, it still sickened me that they were lined up like cattle waiting to be slaughtered. In fact, that's exactly what they were. As I stared at them, I began wondering what kind of lives they had, what families would miss them when they were gone. Sure, I'd coped with my death easily, but my life hadn't been that great either. I hadn't had anyone who would miss me. All of this was bouncing around my skull during Brent's slow march toward the Death Rack, my eyes trained on all these helpless people. And then, staring at them made me realize something entirely different.

They were all blindfolded. That meant they couldn't see me. For the next ten seconds or so, I was free of the rack and there were no human witnesses. My eyes began darting around, desperately searching for something I could use to turn this situation in my favor. We were halfway to the rack when I saw what I was looking for. It would be close, but I had a shot. Brent continued moving forward in that strange, faltering manner. When we were only a few steps away, I sprang to life (so to speak). I snapped the cords tying my arms, pushed off Brent's shoulder, and knocked him off balance. I had a feeling he wouldn't let go. Thankfully, I was able to stagger him enough to make a diving lean for my target.

As I look back, it seems like there were a number of options available to me. I could have grabbed a plank off the bleacher wall and cracked it into my adversary's spine, I could have sunk my fangs into his arms and ripped myself

free, or I even could have used my strength to punch him in the head. I didn't do any of those things. The problem with all of those solutions is that I was never a violent person, and a few death and near-death situations weren't going to change that. I was still me. So, I took advantage of the fact that the Kent party planning committee had anticipated all foreseeable (or so they thought) emergencies.

I pulled myself to the wall and chomped down on a fire extinguisher. I don't know if this is something you've ever had occasions to do; however, I recommend against it unless you have a vampire's jaws and body temperature because that stuff comes out fast, and it comes out cold. In seconds a white mist had filled the air around me, coating everything with the slick, white, flame-dousing foam. I said a silent "thank you" that it was a full-size model and not a dinky miniature. I wriggled free of Brent's grip in the confusion, taking care once I hit the ground due to its slipperiness. From the startled yelps and sounds of impact, it seemed that the werewolves couldn't maneuver so well in these conditions.

I felt Brent shift from beside me and rear back. By the time his fist struck the wall, I was on his opposite side. It took only a well-timed shove to send him sprawling to the ground where he scuttled around, trying to get footing. I must say I took extreme pleasure in that part. The initial mist was already clearing, though the white foam was going nowhere, so I capitalized on the chance to free my fellow classmates.

I didn't bother freeing their hands; instead I pulled a knife from a nearby gladiator costume and began cutting the cords that held them to the wall. Tearing off their blindfolds as I went left them free to escape if they wanted, albeit their hands were still tied in the matter. Heh, heh.

They were funneling out of the door to the south, and I was making good progress, but the werewolves were regaining their footing. I was only a quarter of the way through, and it began to look like that was all I would get done. The whole pack was in pure wolf form now, and with four feet on the ground and no mist in the eyes, they were rising like the tide from that cold, damp floor. I'd done all I could do, and now my only choices were to free as

many as I could before they attacked, or to run like the hounds of hell were chasing me . . . which they would be.

I flipped over the knife in my hand a few times and swallowed out of habit. No more clever justifications or stall tactics left, no way to convince myself the people I left behind would find their own way out. Anyone I left here would undoubtedly die. Painfully. Whatever I did now, I'd have to live with for the rest of my unlife. I looked at the four, behemoth killing machines advancing toward me, then at the shivering humans helplessly lined up along the wall.

I made my decision.

That's when the gunshots rang out.

## 7.

“You were really waiting back in the commentator’s box that whole time?” I asked.

“Well, not the whole time,” Krystal said. “I saw them take you down, so I followed where they brought you. The box had been trashed and I figured they’d realized I was gone. It seemed like the best place for me to be was the one I knew they wouldn’t look.” She poured five packets of sugar into her coffee, followed by at least three creamer packets. Stirring without spilling was shaping up to be an ordeal.

Krystal and I, still in costume no less, were sitting in a small all-night diner a few miles away from the high school. It was 3 a.m., and the emergency vehicles could still be seen heading to and fro along the highway.

“I have to wonder, what will the official story be on this?” I said as she began slurping down her diabetes in a cup.

“Mental breakdown by charismatic former athlete prompted him to create a murder cult.” Her words came between rapid gulps of the steaming beverage.

“And our part in it?”

“Never happened. Local law enforcement responded with quick, surgical precision and averted a potential catastrophe. Sadly, the cult members were unwilling to listen to reason and had to be brought down. Two men on the force will be getting promotions.”

I shook my head. “You don’t think the two men receiving these rewards will be a little suspicious?”

“I think that this happens more than you might expect, and that the men who receive them will be chosen because they are either too dumb or too smart to question it.”

Our conversation was cut short by the doddering waitress finally arriving with our food. Egg white omelet for me, waffles and bacon for Krystal. I lectured her for at least five minutes on cholesterol after she ordered. We dug into our food, but my eating was more for appearance's sake. I'd taken a healthy draw from my flask while driving over, so I was quite full after the night's festivities. We dined in peace for a few minutes. Krystal spoke up midway through the food, words slurred and muffled by her syrup-slathered batter morsels.

“So, when did you die anyway?” she asked. I started to choke on my omelet, then remembered I didn't need to breathe. I swallowed the lump down slowly.

“I have no idea what you mean.”

“Sure you do. You're a vampire.” She didn't look at me or slow down her intake while making her accusations. Impressive.

“I'm an accountant, Krystal, though tonight I was costumed as a doctor. I live alone in my two-bedroom apartment and watch a lot of movies in my free time. Nothing about me really screams vampire.” As I finished my rebuttal, she took a long draw from her coffee cup. Putting it down, she wiped her mouth and pushed her food to the side. She locked eyes with me.

“Fact number one, you rescued me where the door to the corridor was locked, which means your only way in was to scale the wall. You did so without making any noise, or I would have noticed. Fact two, you were one of the most skeptical people I ever knew, and yet when I told you the world was full of monsters, all you wanted was information on one type of them. Fact three, I tailed you after you left the commentator's box and watched your little circus show on top of the cars. You've never been nearly athletic or coordinated to pull anything like that off. Fact four, you jerked free of a werewolf and bit through a damn fire extinguisher. Despite what you might think, I'm good at my job and you're not very practiced at hiding your nature.

Now will you give it up and just answer my question so I can keep eating?” She cocked an eyebrow with her ending question, waiting for me to respond. I motioned for her to go ahead and she began shoveling her food again.

“It’s nothing too exciting. I got grabbed off the street about a year ago and fainted from the shock. When I woke up, I was like this.”

“Kept the same job, huh?”

“Yes. I like what I do, and I didn’t see any reason to give it up.”

“Makes sense. Want to go out tomorrow night?”

“What?!!” In my defense, I didn’t have a lot of experience with beautiful women asking me out. She took it in stride.

“You’re a nice guy. We’ve got a good history. Plus, you aren’t that hard on the eyes. Besides, you actually know what I do for a living. Do you know how nice it will be to go out with a guy who I don’t have to keep lying to?”

I mulled it over. “How do you know I’m not a bad vampire? What if I’m the kind you have to hunt down?”

“You aren’t. I called in your plates while I drove over here. You’ve got a spotless reputation. A pretty boring one, actually.” She gave me a wink with a grin tugging on her mouth.

And there it was. My unlife was so boring that even the woman who hunted monsters saw me as harmless. The one risk I had taken had backfired horribly. I wound up chased, beaten, and nearly killed by werewolves.

Of course, I was sitting across from a very good looking woman who was asking me on a date. Maybe my first risk hadn’t played out so badly in the end. Maybe it was time for another. After all, I did still have four days of clean clothes and blood. Plenty of time to schedule some spontaneity.

“I’ll pick you up after sunset,” I told her, mustering all my courage and including a flirtatious smile with my invitation.

# A Zombie at the LARP

## 1.

When I woke up the morning after being turned into a vampire, I knew some things were going to have to change. I would not be able to make it into work at the accounting firm anymore, I would have to forgo any walks into sunshine, and I would need to get used to a far more liquid-based diet. These were things I understood and accepted with a humble grace. What I did not expect was that the accounting business I started to accommodate my new lifestyle would explode with popularity.

At a time when most people were making plans for the upcoming Thanksgiving holiday, I was working around the clock trying to meet deadlines for all the new clients I had recently received. I'm not exaggerating, either. We vampires don't have to sleep during the day; we just have the option. At night I can take enough Percocet to kill a bear and still be wide eyed. In the day, however, the mystical forces that animate my now-dead body relent and allow me to slip into slumber. At least they did before the rush of work had kept me up for three nights and days straight.

It was really my own fault. I had taken some time off to attend my high school reunion and come back to a mountain of new assignments that had arrived in my absence. I could have turned some of them down, of course, but that would have involved talking on the phone, and possibly yelling or shouting, and the truth is, I'm just not very good at confrontations.

Now, I know what you're thinking. Who ever heard of a vampire that

was scared of conflict? Well, I was non-confrontational in life, so I am still non-confrontational in death. Yes, we vampires are portrayed as a group of, for lack of a better term, “badasses,” but as far as I can tell, we are greatly similar to who we were when our hearts still beat, only with paler skin and more physical prowess. Granted, that is based solely on my experience because I have made no effort to seek out others of my kind. The only run in I had had with other supernatural beings happened at my aforementioned reunion, and it had been anything but low stress.

As I clapped a pair of documents together and joined them with a paperclip, I let out a sigh. Yes, I can still sigh, and I still make a habit of intaking oxygen with my lungs, though I do not know if it still qualifies as breathing at this point. I was nearing the end of this week’s work, but I still had hours of filing and data entry left. It was tedious work that required no special skills and was usually outsourced to temps or assistants. Since I had neither and suspected none would be willing to work with someone of my . . . condition, that meant the grunt work fell firmly on my own narrow shoulders.

I went to the fridge and pulled out a thermos, then popped it in the microwave. After a few minutes it was ready, and I all but cannonballed it. I overeat when stressed, which is why I was a portlier fellow in my living days. Now all I have to worry about is a larger bill for the blood I buy, but with all this work, it would be easy to afford. I could always cut that cost in theory, but my few attempts at feedings were less than spectacular. The last of these excursions, a pitiful effort capping off a string of failures, began with trying to skulk along a rooftop as I trailed a lone pedestrian, followed by tripping on loose brick and cracking myself in the mouth, then ended with me taking a tumble into a nearby apartment’s dumpster. That was when I learned the downside of vampire senses, along with the fact that the building in question hosted an unusually large number of babies still in diapers. There was no dry-cleaning out that smell from a pair of khakis. So, I just purchase my blood from a business acquaintance that runs a local hospital and has need for the services of an exceptional accountant.

Dabbing my mouth with one of my black napkins (you can only imagine



the stains I got when I still used white ones), I washed out my thermos and began heading back to my desk. I worked in my apartment, which was windowless and possessed excellent security. I also had all work sent and returned via a courier service. It made sure I could lead the lifestyle I desired in the privacy I loved. Aside from the courier, there were only a few people who knew my address, and my apartment complex was not the sort where uninvited guests could saunter in to talk to the residents about religion or the incredible savings opportunity that they were presenting to a select few.

Which is the reason the thundering knock on my door garnered such a severe and shocked reaction from me, as I leapt several feet in the air and let out a small squeak. I am not exaggerating about the distance I jumped. I did mention the undead lifestyle comes with a few side perks. One of them is muscular ability beyond the range of human limitations. Another was heightened senses, which told me there was the heartbeat of one person outside my door at that moment. I know what you're thinking; if I could hear so well, how did they catch me by surprise? Well, I don't go around using my heightened senses willy-nilly. Just think of how distracting that would be, especially when I am trying to get work done.

Gathering my composure, I walked over to the door, undid several deadbolts, and pulled it open a few inches to see who would disturb a working vampire in the evening. As it turned out, the answer was a tall, curvy blonde in grey slacks and a red, buttoned-down, collared shirt. The colors didn't do much to accentuate her chocolate brown eyes, but the confidence reflecting out of them was all the accentuation they needed.

"Hey, Freddy," Krystal said, slipping her way past the door and giving me a hug.

"How did you know where I lived?" I asked. I was excited to see her, and should have really done a better job showing it, but at that precise moment, the fear from the surprise was still surging strongly through me.

"We've been through this, Freddy. Mysterious agency, no name that I can give out, impossible connections and information sources—you know the drill. Got any beer?" She kissed me on the cheek and meandered over to my

fridge. Getting a hold of myself, I shut the door firmly and re-engaged all of my locks, then turned my attention to the blonde rifling through my meagerly stocked refrigerator.

Krystal and I had gone to school together and had run in similar social circles. By that I mean we were both shunted to the bottom with the rest of the dregs and forced to be friends with other people no one else liked. Time, along with a good dietician and an active lifestyle, had changed her body and found her in the employment of an agency dedicated to dealing with supernatural creatures and events. We had become reacquainted at our high school reunion during an attack from a group of former football-star werewolves, and struck up something of a romantic interlude before I had returned home. Again, though, I wondered if we were drawn together out of necessity, her living a life she couldn't tell a normal man about, and me . . . well me being of those things that aren't allowed to be talked about.

"We have *got* to get you stocking some beer. Merlot, blood, and brie are all that's in here. You're killing me, Freddy." She shut the fridge door and gave me one of her careless smiles. Whatever her lifestyle had done to her over the past ten years, it had certainly made her beautiful. Perhaps this wasn't just about convenience.

"Well, I would have prepared if I had known you were coming by. I haven't seen you since our date after the reunion fiasco," I said.

"Ugh, I know. Sorry about that. Had to fly to Greece to track down some marauding ghouls. Took forever, and the company plan doesn't cover unauthorized international calls to undead romantic interests," she said, waltzing over to my couch and plopping down.

"Ah yes, well . . . they, um . . . they don't actually know we went out, do they? I mean, I imagine they would be less than chipper to learn one of their agents is dating a vampire," I said, sitting down in the chair set catty-corner to the couch.

"Of course they know. I reported it in before we even went out. No cares about that though. They just wouldn't pony up to pay the long distance charges," she said.

“They don’t care that you’re dating a vampire?” I don’t think I did a very good job keeping the shock out of my voice.

“Nope, that would be discriminatory. We work hard to maintain good relationships with all parahuman communities, and that includes Undead Americans,” she explained.

“You must be making this up.”

“Totally serious. There are equal rights laws, a set up voting system, even tax benefits to hiring Undead Americans if you run a business. It’s a big, wide world, Freddy. You should really leave your little bat cave sometime and go see it. You’d be surprised at some of the things out there,” Krystal said, getting up from the couch and coming over to my chair. She set herself gently on my lap. “For example, you could come out with me tonight. We could go to a greasy diner, pick up some decent beer, maybe take in a midnight showing at a movie theatre and not pay attention to what’s on the screen.”

“I, uh . . . um . . . yes . . . well . . .” Being a vampire grants you many things. A sudden burst of intuition and confidence with the opposite sex sitting directly on top of you is sadly not one of them.

Krystal laughed. “Glad to see you still get flustered so easily. It was always one of your more adorable traits. So, you want to come?”

“Well . . . ahem . . . I suppose I have almost caught up on tonight’s work.”

“Great!” Krystal hopped from my lap and pulled me up with her. “It’ll be tons of fun. Just you, and me, and the city at night.” She began unlocking my door and pulling it open. “There’s just one little thing I have to stop and do while we’re out. Quick errand, won’t take a minute.” With that she unlatched the final lock and all but bounced out the door.

“What kind of errand?” I asked as I hurried to catch up, stopping outside to lock all of the bolts. She paid no attention to me though, galloping down the hallway and out into the parking lot.

“Krystal?” I called as I finished locking and moved briskly out into the parking lot. “I’m serious. Where are we going? What kind of errand?”

## 2.

“Welcome, everyone, and thank you for coming to this week’s Black Banshee Role Playing Game.” The speaker was young, maybe sixteen or seventeen, wearing what had to be a suit from the 1950’s and sporting glasses and a haircut that matched. He moved with a strange confidence; then again, perhaps it was just strange because it was confidence of any kind in this setting.

Scattered around me were a variety of people, ranging in age from the frequent teenager to the more elusive adult. Most were wearing somewhat elaborate costumes. Many of them sported fake fangs and were wearing makeup in order to pale their skin, a few wore heavily furred gloves and wolf masks, and there was even one person who looked to have stolen his ghost-sheet costume straight out of Charlie Brown.

“As all of you should know, my name is Neil, and I will be your Game Master this evening. Now, since all of you registered your characters beforehand, my assistant Albert will be working the table near the front. We do ask that you check in, take your badge, and keep it somewhere visible all night long. Your badge identifies your character name, race, and what faction you belong to, if any. I’ll remind those of you who are new to our LARP, any information on the badge that is in black is considered general knowledge, and information on the badge that is in red is known only to those of you in the same race. Gaining that information will have to happen through interaction, so please, no metagaming. Albert will also hand you our general rules sheet, so check in as soon as possible. Once everyone is accounted for,

we can get this game started!” He threw his fist in the air at that last line, then took a deep bow. He left his soapbox of a stage (yes, it was actually a soapbox; no, I have no idea where he found such a thing) to the sound of scattered clapping.

If you are wondering, I was most certainly not one of those clapping.

“Please explain to me how this is an errand,” I told Krystal with as much unfriendliness as I was able to conjure into my voice. It wasn’t much.

“It’s no big deal,” she said, taking my hand and leading me over to a line that had sprung up around a large folding table decorated with badges, sheets of a paper, and one solo attendant (presumably Albert) doing his damndest to keep up with the influx of people swarming him. “There have been some reports of a shambling figure seen here after hours, and a few reports of missing animals. Ten bucks says it’s just some kid staying late to practice his act and a coincidental upturn in runaways, but I have to come check this out anyway.”

“Well . . . how long does it usually last?” I asked, already feeling the familiar symptoms of caving in to doing what someone else wanted me to.

“Only three hours, and we should be gone in half of that,” Krystal said. She wrapped her arms around me, then slithered her hand up to my head and gently raked her fingernails through my hair while pressing close to me, making her . . . non-mental assets very apparent. “I promise there will still be ample time to go ignore a movie,” she purred.

One thing about being a vampire that doesn’t entirely suck, pun unremorsefully intended, is the ability to sense and pick up on things humans miss all the time. For example, when Krystal wrapped herself around me like that, I heard her heart beat increase, felt the warmth of blood flow to various places, and smelled the increase of pheromones she was putting out. It’s one thing to have a beautiful woman blatantly flirting with you; it’s a whole other thing to have biological evidence she really means it.

“Um . . . well . . . we . . . okay,” I said, giving in, to no one’s surprise (especially not my own). Krystal kissed me on the cheek and pulled back her body while dialing down the sex appeal, though not quite letting either slip

away from me entirely.

“You’re the best, Freddy. And who knows? You might even have fun.”

“I seriously doubt that,” I said as we moved ever so slowly through the throng of would-be players clamoring for their badges.

“Why not?” Krystal asked.

“I can’t do pretend very well. I mean, I like the idea of acting, but I get so nervous. Remember when I tried out for the theatre program sophomore year? I vomited all over the stage before I finished my first line.”

“Oh yeah, you know I’d forgotten that,” she said. “Still, it wasn’t as bad as when you tried out for choir.”

“Let us not visit that rest stop on memory road. My stomach is churning already,” I said.

Krystal let out a surprisingly throaty laugh. It drew looks from the few un-distracted players around us. I suppose they were sensitive to the idea of laughter, but upon seeing it wasn’t directed at them, most just turned their attention back to the table. There were a few who didn’t, and given how Krystal looked in comparison to most of the others there, I could hardly blame them.

“You can’t throw up, dum-dum,” Krystal told me when she was done giggling. “I mean that literally. Your kind doesn’t have the ability to do that.”

“We don’t?” I asked.

“Have you tried?”

“Why on earth would I try?” I said, a touch exasperated that she still seemed to know more about what I was than I did.

“Hmm, good point. Yes, you can’t puke. It’s one of those things you lost.”

“Oh,” I said. I didn’t mean for it to sound sad. It certainly wasn’t a great loss, the ability to void my stomach in a backwards direction, but it was yet again one more thing that made me less human. Those were becoming all too frequent for my liking.

“Cheer up, buttercup,” Krystal said as we reached the front of the line. She whispered to me before turning to Albert the attendant, “One day I’ll help

you discover all of the things you've gained. I think you'll be pleasantly surprised by a few of them. I know I will." With that line lingering in my ear and echoing through my libido, she did an about face to speak with the young man staring up (though not quite as up as he should have been to see her face) at her.

"Krystal Jenkins and Freddy Fletcher checking in," she said with a warm smile. It seemed to catch poor Albert off guard, as he suddenly turned flustered and began digging about for our badges. Of course, given how unfriendly everyone seemed to have been to him, I could understand why he would falter at a changeup. He was young and wore a dirty black shirt and dirtier black pants. I wasn't sure what the organizer had made him do before this, but I only imagine it involved digging because that kid reeked of earth. Not a bad smell really, just a potent one.

He finally found our badges and handed them both to Krystal. He hesitated for a moment before letting go and looked at mine, then up at me, then back at mine.

"Is that what you're going to wear?" Albert asked in a not-quite-squeaky, not-quite-grown-up teenage voice. Though the question was probing, his tone was surprisingly friendly.

I looked at my ensemble. I was wearing a robin's egg blue sweater vest on top of a white buttoned-down shirt along with a pair of black slacks and sensible black shoes. I did stand out a bit compared to everyone else, but I hadn't really been told to dress for this, now had I?

"Um, is that a problem?" I asked him.

"Not a problem, just wondering. Your character is your character," he said, handing me a sheet of paper, then motioned me to the side so he could help the next person. "Personally, I think it's really neat that you decided to take your costume in a different direction. You two have a great night."

I joined Krystal a few strides away from the line. "What's wrong with my outfit?" I asked her.

"It doesn't fit your character so well," she said, a wicked grin lighting up her face.

“Oh, yes, on that note, this whole event requires registration and character creation beforehand. So how is it that you just happened to have an ID badge ready for me and under my name?” I asked, really just for form. The answer was all too obvious.

“I thought this would suck, so I wanted company. Sexy, dangerous, vampire company,” she said, the laughing smile staying firmly on her face as she reached out and put her hand against my chest.

“Shhh!” I fervently whispered, welling up with panic. “What if someone hears you?”

“Check your badge there, Freddy. It’s black-print information. Everyone will know when they see you,” Krystal said, pulling her own badge out and affixing it to her shirt.

“Huh?” I said idiotically, and I looked at the front of my clothes. Sure enough, clearly slipped on there when she touched my chest, was my badge affixed carefully on the breast pocket of my sweater vest. It took me a moment to unravel its words as I read them upside down.

It said: “Name: Count Fredrick. Race: Vampire.” Then in red print below that it said: “Faction: Revivalist. “

“You made me a vampire?”

“You did say you hated pretending.”

“Are you one too?” I asked, not bothering to read her tag. Given where she had attached it on her shirt, I could see no easy way to read it without being something of a pervert.

“I’m Sunny the Succubus,” she said, her voice up a few registers and her tone lilting. She sounded like a mixed breed between the stereotype of a cheerleader and the stereotype of a valley girl.

“What’s a succubus?” I asked.

“Demon slut,” she said simply in her own voice. Ah, well then, that made the accent quite appropriate. I wondered for a moment just how much time she put into preparing for this role. This short thought process was interrupted as she took my hand once more.

“Looks like they’re almost ready to start,” she said, slipping back into her



character tones. “Come on. Let’s go mingle!”

### 3.

“All right, everyone, thank you all for checking in,” Neil the Game Master said as he climbed back atop his soapbox to address us. Something about this kid still struck me as weird. It wasn’t the clothing or the style either; he was odd, but nowhere near the weirdest guy in attendance. It’s just something in the way he moved. I couldn’t put my finger on it, but I knew it was there. I didn’t really pay that much mind to it, though. I mean, after all, I was a vampire who hid the fact that he was a vampire who was standing in a park pretending to be the thing that I usually pretend I’m not. Who was I to throw stones at weird?

“Before we begin, I just want to go over the rules on your sheets so that everyone knows the system, and we can all have fun. To start with, we do not do realistic battle simulations here. I saw some of you bring your foam weapons, but, unfortunately, we’ve had some lawsuit trouble in the past and have decided it’s not worth the risk. Any fighting will be resolved by a match of rock-paper-scissors. If you fight someone of the same race, then it will be a best 2-out-of-3 match to represent how much more difficult these fights are,” Neil said, reading from his sheet out to the crowd. I heard mumbles as a few costumed participants set down large, foam-weapon recreations on the ground, faces all but dripping in disappointment. Albert scuttled around swiftly gathering up the weapons and setting them on the folding table where the badges had been.

“Now then, aside from combat, all of you have your own powers and abilities. These are written on the backs of your badges should you forget or

need to prove to another player this is a power you really possess. Success is considered automatic, unless another player has immunity to that particular ability. In cases where a player with a power deals with another player who only has a resistance to that power, and not an immunity, we will again be going to the rock-paper-scissors method of resolving who comes out on top,” Neil continued. If that made no sense to you, don’t feel bad. I was slack-jawed and flummoxed by the time he finished that part. I simply hoped I would either figure it out as I played or be gone soon enough that it wouldn’t matter.

“Last, but certainly not least, this is a Live Action Role Playing game. All of you being of different races and factions have gathered here as the new emperor of the city requested to try and forge an alliance between the various supernatural cultures living in his domain. For this to be the most enjoyable event it can be, I ask that you truly commit to your roles. Do not break character unless it is a vital emergency. In this way, we can forget the names we have behind our badges and truly immerse ourselves into tonight’s identities.” I had to admit, I was a touch envious; this kid was a better public speaker than I had ever been. I’d tried to correct that particular failing on many occasions, each an unmitigated disaster, often with gastrointestinal consequences. “And now, I’ll ask you to meet up with those of your race and faction as you arrive at the emperor’s ball. When I step down from here, the game has begun, and I am your ruler: Emperor Nikolai.”

He didn’t step down as much as hop, but the symbolism was there, and we got the message. I turned to ask Krystal what I should do now, only to find her gone. I whipped my head around looking for her, but before I could do more than look to my side, a small hand grabbed me by the shoulder.

The small hand belonged to a proportionally small woman, maybe early twenties in age, wearing heavy white makeup and a long black trench coat coupled with a corset and leather pants. Her badge told me her character name was Maria, and that she was a vampire like me. The fake fangs I saw a moment later when she spoke assured me that she was definitely a vampire only while this game was in progress.

“Good evening, Count Fredrick. Our Lord Drake will be so pleased another nightwalker loyal to the cause has joined us this evening,” she said, slurring slightly due to the fangs.

“Um . . . yay, and verily I hath come?”

The look she gave me said quite clearly my vampire impression had missed the mark. Luckily for me the girl was a pro; she rolled with it well. “There is no need to imitate the high language, Count Fredrick. Clearly you were turned recently, so this generation’s tongue is your own. Speak freely and comfortably, for our Lord Drake cares nothing of cultural differences, only of loyalty and dedication. We are all equally united under our cause.”

“Okay . . . thanks. And, you know, just so I know we’re on the same page here, which cause are you talking about? I’m active in a few of them actually. I used to do walks for cancer before the whole turning thing and—”

Mercifully Maria cut me off with one finger against my lips and one pointing to the red writing on my badge that said “Revivalist.” I finally noticed she had the same writing on her own. The pieces fell into place. Well, admittedly, they were more jammed into place forcefully, but I got the point, and that was what mattered.

“Oh, yes, right! The true cause. Forgive me, I have not eaten anyone in a few days, and I’ve grown a bit muddled round the temples, if you know what I mean,” I said, thinking on my feet. I really did get foggy when I went a few days without blood, so hopefully that was a part of this vampire mythos as well.

“Of course, good Count. With the preparations for tonight’s event, all of us have been exceptionally busy. I can hardly fault you for putting the cause’s success over the needs of your own thirst. Worry not, for tonight enough blood shall flow to sate the hunger in all of our throats. But enough talk here . . . we must hurry to meet with Lord Drake. Time is already short, and even the lesser monsters have ears with which to hear,” Maria said, tugging me toward a big cluster of trees.

We went through that cluster, then through a few more, down a twisting dirt road, and then through more trees. I was making a mental note to myself

to take a free night and see just how big this freaking park was when we broke into a clearing. It would have seemed like a natural clearing one might stumble into in a real forest, save for the dozen figures in makeup and the picnic table located in the center.

“Ah, my maiden Maria returns to us from her mission seeking stragglers,” said a large man wearing a velvet ruffled shirt, a leather cape, and what looked like combat boots.

“Aye, my Lord Drake, I come bearing Count Fredrick. His invitation to meet us separately from the others of our ilk was lost, so I escorted him to join us tonight,” Maria said, using her jacket to do a curtsy as she spoke. I had to give the girl credit; she was good at this. She knew I had no idea what was going on and had still managed to weave me into this story quite nicely.

“Arise, my servant,” said the large man who I could only surmise was Lord Drake. “We have much to do this eve, and so precious little time to do it.” Lord Drake turned to me. “And you, good Count, we thank you for your support. As you can see, our force is small, so we shall seek victory through strategy and cunning. A single, loyal vampire may very well be the difference between success and failure.”

Lord Drake walked back over to the picnic table and settled down his considerable heft. The other “vampires” followed suit, so I made my way over as well. I had no idea what Krystal was up to, but it seemed like my best bet was to play along and blend in until she finished her job, and we could bail.

“My dark children,” Lord Drake began. “For too long we have been forced to live this way. Feeding in secret, locked within the shadows, existing as nothing more than myth and fancy in the eyes of the cattle we call humans.” There were mumbles of agreement that rippled through the table. I myself made mumbles of non-committal curiosity. The differences are subtle, but very important.

“We have suffered much humiliation at the hands of those in charge. Worse yet, most of our kind have been domesticated. They truly believe a vampire is meant to slink and sip, instead of dominate and destroy. We are the

strongest beasts here, and yet we walk as if dogs with tails between our legs, ashamed of our own power and grandeur.” The agreement was getting a touch more boisterous now. I was oddly reminded of pep rallies in high school. Everyone was getting fired up around me, yet it was abundantly clear that I was not a part of what was going on.

“And now, the final insult. A mere human trickster, a mage, being made the emperor of our sweet city. This is a blow which I fear we cannot bear. I will not bow to cattle. I will not scrape my knee to the ground for nothing more than a human with a few cantrips. That is why we gather here tonight, my dark children, so that we may carry out our plan to revive our rightful place in this world’s hierarchy.”

They weren’t mumbling anymore; they were downright cheering. The only ones who were moderately subdued were me and my guide, Maria, who just stared on with wonder and fascination in her eyes.

“Tonight, we do what should have been done long ago. Tonight we remind this world that vampires are creatures to be feared, not handled. Tonight we leave the shadows and put ourselves back on the path toward our rightful place of rulers over the cattle and the lesser monsters.” Lord Drake leaned in closely now, and the cheering died in an instant. Everyone was still as death, no pun intended, as the great Lord Drake licked his lips and let his next words fly.

“Tonight, my dark children, we kill the emperor!”

## 4.

“I have *got* to stop leaving the apartment,” I mumbled to myself as we skulked through the forest towards the main area where everyone was assembled. I mean “skulked” in a very literal way. It seems all of we Revivalist vampires had an ability to blend in with the scenery and become more or less invisible. According to the back of the badge, the way we signified this was by moving hunching over and moving carefully, as well as putting up our index fingers on both sides of our heads.

That’s right; I was hunching my way through the forest with finger horns. Somehow, when I was human and dreamed about a different kind of life, one where I was powerful and immortal, this was a scenario I had never imagined. Most of those fantasies had been cheap rip-offs of well-done films, involving me being socially gregarious as well as unstoppably cool. I couldn’t even fathom what would make someone incorporate something this asinine into their own fantasies. Still, I was supposed to blend, so blend I did.

It took us considerable time to get back to the main event, mostly because of our slow moving pace, but finally we parted a section of trees and found ourselves facing the mingling crowd and a folding table stocked with foam weapons. Lord Drake jerked his head northward, and we began our agonizing walk in that direction.

Let me tell you something: I’ve been forced to do some ridiculous things in my lifetime. I’ve put my head in the toilet for swirlies, eaten dirt, even been made to dance like a cha-cha girl on one humiliating occasion, all to avoid being beaten up. For the dickens though, I cannot imagine what would make

someone willingly do what we did as we crept through the crowd. We did our hunch walk with our finger horns, skulking through them, all the while pretending they couldn't see us. Adding to the oddness, they all clearly noticed us and wanted to know what was going on, but had to pretend we were invisible.

It was like embarrassment and stupidity, compacted. To their credit, not one person broke character and approached us, and we moved past the majority of the players into a more open area on the north side of the park. From there we could see Emperor Nikolai speaking in hushed tones to some of the other players. One of them was the person with the Charlie Brown ghost costume, and one looked to be wearing a werewolf mask, so they were pretty obvious. The other two I recognized even more easily, though. They were Albert the Henchman and my own dear Sunny the Succubus.

I briefly wondered why she was a part of the little pow-wow, but I guessed it made sense. If you need to investigate, why not go right to the top?

None of that changed the plan, though. Lord Drake had known that Emperor Nikolai would be speaking to a few delegates at a time, with only his servant Albert as protection. I wasn't sure what kind of monster Albert was, and I hadn't had a chance to ask, but Lord Drake seemed pretty certain we would be able to overpower him easily. The goal here was for us to creep up on the separated few and spring into action. Each of us was supposed to do battle with one of the delegates, while Lord Drake and two of his servants took down the emperor. That way the "kill" would be assigned to Lord Drake and he would then have cause to lobby that he should be the new emperor. New emperor means he makes the rules, which means no more hiding from the humans, and yada yada yada.

The main point I had gleaned from all of that was I needed to pick a person and play rock-paper-scissors with them. Either they won, or I did. After that none of this was my problem anymore, and hopefully Krystal was ready to go.

We resumed our skulking, moving delicately, yet purposefully, toward our soon-to-be-deposed emperor. Lord Drake, Maria, and another girl broke



off to circle around toward the rear where the emperor was located. The rest of us continued creeping up on our targets. Since I was near her side anyway, I locked my vision on Krystal and decided to “battle” her. I think it was because I was focused only on her that I noticed the quick gesture she made, scratching the top of her nose with her thumb. I had only an instant to ponder why she would use a thumb instead of a finger, when strange words rang through the air.

“*Ectorim Novendum, Bicradalio.*” It was Neil’s voice, and it rang out with authority and power, more than I would have ever thought the kid capable of. When he spoke again, it was somewhat less impressive.

“As you have all noticed, you are now frozen in place thanks to my spell,” Emperor Nikolai said, closing the large black tome he had obviously read from and handing it to Albert. “None of you have applicable immunities or resistances, and yes, we are quite aware that you Revivalists are here. Your camouflage power was dispelled the moment I froze you.”

There was a ripple of gasping and shock from our vampires as well as nearby players.

“I’d suspected for some time you might try an uprising, so I took necessary precautions,” he continued. At this point Krystal, or I should say *Sunny*, bounced over and stood smiling dumbly as he slipped an arm around her. “My new consort here is a succubus, and as most of you should know, they possess the ability to see past all veils and illusions.”

Emperor Nikolai released his grip on Sunny and walked over to Lord Drake, who, to his credit, was remaining stock still, and leaned into Drake’s face. “So, the great Lord Drake reduced to nothing more than a mere mannequin. How elegantly pathetic. You underestimated me Drake; you thought that just because I was genetically a human I would go down easy. After all, what possible threat can a mere mage be?” Emperor Nikolai stepped back from Drake and walked back over to his own group, picking up the black book from Albert’s waiting hands.

“You should have done a little research first, Drake. You might have realized I’m not just a mage. I’m a necromancer, a spell caster with power

over all forms of death, and that includes the undead. Binding you walking corpses required little more effort from me than turning a page.” Emperor Nikolai gave Drake a look of sheer condescension, gloating without restraint. “Now the only question is what to do with you all. I think I shall unbind you, after wrapping you in silver chains of course, so that Albert may escort you back into the forest. I will finish up my party with my dear subjects, and spend the time thinking of a fitting punishment for you.”

With that the emperor clapped his hands, and Albert pulled a large chest from behind a tree. He began pulling out long lengths of chain as well as several padlocks. Albert started with Lord Drake, then slowly made his way to each of us, covering us in the chains so we could barely move, and connecting us into one giant undead chain gang.

None of which was my biggest concern. You see, my problem had started the minute good old Neil had shouted those gibberish words. I was frozen like ice, unable to move even my own eyes. That spell of his had been real, and I was captured by it, which meant three things:

1. I wasn't the only real monster here.
2. I was the worst possible race to try and stop him.
3. We were in deep shit. *Again.*

## 5.

Walking back into the forest was something of a chore. Neil had used another spell to unfreeze us, and it had given me back my range of motion, but there was still the fact that we were all shackled together that made the commute pretty challenging. Adding onto that was that Albert had been oddly thorough in chaining our hands behind our backs and our legs close together. Everyone else seemed to be pretty into the scene, impressed that Neil had planned this far ahead and gone to such lengths for realism.

I was the only one truly concerned, but that was because I was the only one who knew Neil had used a set of real spells and had bound us with real chains, though thankfully not real silver ones. Silver doesn't hurt me, per se, but it does weaken me and, if exposed to my skin, makes me break out in a terrible rash. Even with undead regeneration, it takes days to fade. Seriously, ten buckets of calamine won't soothe the itch that gleaming metal leaves behind.

Albert was moving up and down the line, giving direction to the front while coordinating our movements in the back. Officially he was there to make sure none of us tried to escape. I think in truth he was just making sure we didn't go tumbling down like a row of dominoes. I watched him as he moved, watched him more carefully than I had the rest of that evening. He was quick with his movements, not quite fluid, but well above jerky. He was about as pale as the rest of the made-up vampire squad, but a few shades above my own dead skin. And he still reeked of earth. This kid must have either been playing in the mud every time we didn't see him or have spent a

few days marinating in dirt.

I'm sure a few of you have gotten there already, but this was the point where it all finally sunk home. Constantly obedient, reeked of earth, dirty clothes, and paler than normal skin; it was clear Albert wasn't alive. I focused my hearing, first noticing the sounds of the forest, then the mingling partygoers to my rear, and then at last I heard the heartbeats of those around me. My senses seemed to hone in on that, like they'd been looking for it all along. I shook off the implications of what that probably meant and began listening to one person at a time. Once I was confident I had heard a beat from everyone of my captured cohorts, I turned my focus to Albert.

I got nothing. Not a heartbeat, not a gasp for air—nothing but the sounds of his bones scraping and muscles twanging as he scampered about. Hey, I said vampire senses were powerful, not that they weren't gross.

All of this sounds like it happened quickly, but the truth is that between splitting my focus on listening and walking we had finally reached our destination by the time I confirmed my Albert hypothesis. He moved down the line, wearing a giant smile as he was helping each of us sit down on the ground so we would be comfortable while we waited for the emperor to come judge us. I was at the end of the line, so I was left standing till the end.

By providence or coincidence, I had been further away from most of the others when we were frozen, which meant I had a fair amount of chain separating me from the player in front of me. I began carefully inching my way backwards. When Albert sat me down, I wanted as much space from anyone else as possible. I had some questions that were most definitely not for public hearing.

It took some time due to Albert's care with helping each player down, but he finally reached me. He stood behind my back and told me to slowly lower my knees. I did as instructed, waiting until my butt was on the ground, and he was bent over my shoulders just about to let go of me before speaking.

"So," I said, trying with all my might to be casual. "What are you anyway, Albert?"

Instead of answering he released his grip and walked around in front of

me. He then took a knee so we were eye to eye and pointed to his badge. There, in clear black ink, it said: “Zombie.”

“Are you really?” I asked, doing what I hoped was arching an eyebrow.

“Of course, I am Albert the Unstoppable Zombie, raised by Emperor Nikolai and existing only to serve his every whim,” Albert declared proudly.

“No . . . damnit, you’re not getting the point. Forget the game. Are you an actual zombie?” I asked again.

Now Albert’s relentlessly cheerful face was getting wary and worried. Even I could tell I was at least on the right track. “Don’t be silly,” he said, hushing his tone slightly. “There’s no such thing as zombies.”

“Right. Just like there’s no such thing as real necromancers who cast real spells and take a bunch of real people chained up out into the woods with no witnesses.”

Albert didn’t say anything after that, just widened his eyes and began chewing on his lower lip.

“Okay, I’ll be honest with you,” I said. “I know you’re a real zombie, and Neil is a real necromancer. I don’t really care about either of those things. Live and let live. That’s my expression. Just tell me that all of this is part of the game, and there is nothing sinister afoot, and I’ll hang out and play along until my date comes to pick me up for the movie. I really don’t want trouble; I just wanted to go to the movies. So just say it’s part of the game. *Please.*”

Albert stopped chewing and just looked at me. He looked very much like a puppy going through potty training that slips up and pees on the rug. Guilty and apologetic, with the resignation that he couldn’t change what had already happened.

“Fudge,” I swore.

“I’m really, really sorry,” Albert said, rocking back off his knee and sitting next to me Indian style. “I wanted to warn you guys, or to stop him, but I just couldn’t.”

“Because you’re a supernatural being under his thrall?” I asked.

“No, because he’s my best friend. My only friend, actually. Even when I was alive it was the two of us. He’d come up with crazy schemes, and I’d

follow along with them. He just got so wrapped up in things. I could never seem to talk him out of stuff. Besides, most of the time I just felt lucky to have even one friend. I mean, there was never all that much interesting about me, and now that I'm dead, I'm even less socially desirable."

"Yeah, I know how that goes," I said, summoning the most consoling tone I could under the circumstances. Okay, sure he had been part of a scheme to kidnap a bunch of people out into the woods for heaven only knew what, but I couldn't help feeling for the kid. I'd been in about the same boat for my whole life, and most of my afterlife. "I wasn't exactly Mr. Popular myself."

"Few people who come to these events are. That's why they were so much fun. I don't imagine you've had it quite that bad, though. I saw the girl you came here with. And besides, at least you're not some undead freak," Albert said. It was weird. Even when trying to mope, his voice still had a happy, sing-songy style.

"Um . . . well . . . that's not entirely true," I said.

Albert looked up from the ground he had been staring at and directly at me. It was less like he was looking at me, though, more like he was studying me carefully. "Just how untrue is it?" Albert asked.

In response I opened my mouth, showing my human looking teeth. With a bit of concentration I did the trick I was finally getting the hang of, letting my canines extend to long, razor-sharp points. I then pulled them back to normal, which was much harder than letting them grow, and closed my mouth.

Albert's, however, hung open in surprise. After a few minutes of opening and closing his jaw, he finally got his tongue back in working order and said, "I guess that explains how you knew Neil was the real deal."

"Unfortunately, yes it does. Wait, you're undead. Why didn't it work on you?"

Albert shrugged. "I think creatures that you animate are immune from your own generic spells. You have to target them directly, or some such protocol. Neil explained it to me once after he brought me back, but I've never been smart enough to understand stuff like that."

“Oh,” I said. We lapsed into silence after that, captor and captive deciding where to go from here. I opted to try and ask the question I’d never been able to ask anyone else since my transformation. I mean, when was I going to get another chance like this?

“So, if it isn’t prying,” I said carefully. “Can I ask how you died?”

There was only silence at first, then I heard Albert’s voice say softly, “I’d rather not talk about it.”

“I understand,” I said quickly. “I can barely even remember my death. It seems like I’ve almost totally blocked it out. If you do remember yours, then I can only guess at how traumatic that must be. I’m sorry I asked. It’s just . . . You’re the first other undead person I’ve met.”

“Ummmm, it isn’t really that it was traumatic. Just embarrassing,” Albert said.

“What makes it so bad?” I asked.

“How much do you know about autoerotic asphyxiation and the accidents that come with it?”

“You know what, I think I’ve got the picture,” I said, words so hurried I nearly broke into a stutter. “So . . . that happened, then Neil brought you back. Was he always a necromancer?”

“Nah,” Albert said quickly, obviously grateful to be off the topic of his death. “He was a science geek for years. He used to make fun of me for loving the occult and stuff like this. But after I died, apparently he went off the deep end a little bit. He even went to his grandpa for help.” Albert gave his head a small shake, sending strands of his long, moderately unkempt hair in front of his dark eyes.

“Was his grandfather a necromancer too?” I asked, getting drawn in a bit.

“Not that we know of, but his grandmother was a real famous medium back in the day. Before she died, she accumulated a bunch of supposedly magical stuff, and one of the things there was that black book.”

“Gotcha. So he found the book, gave it a try, and, low and behold, it’s the real deal,” I said, finishing the story in my mind.

“More or less. Apparently, you also have to have the talent for the magic

to work, which Neil has, and he tried a few times before he brought me back. But yeah, one day my eyes popped open, and I'm underground. Crawl my way out, and there's my best friend, cackling like a mental patient and saying he's uncovered the magics of the gods."

"Sounds like your friend went on a power trip," I said carefully.

"I know. He's gotten more and more obsessed with it, too. He keeps saying he needs greater power, needs to expand his abilities, needs to steal people's life force—" Albert shut his mouth quickly, but unfortunately not even zombies can clam up fast enough to steal their own words back.

"Ah, so that's what this is about. Let me guess . . . ancient rite, kills us all, and uses our souls, or life force, or whatever to gather tremendous power for himself?" I asked already knowing the answer.

Albert was clearly impressed. "Are you a necromancer too?"

"No." I sighed. "I'm just a numbers guy, and that means I can see an obvious pattern when it's set in front of me. Look, Albert, you seem like a good guy. We need to get out of here, and you're the one with the keys. You know what your friend is doing is wrong, so hurry and help us before—"

"Good evening, my rebellious subjects!" Neil said as he stepped into the clearing, large black tome in hand. "I trust you have all had time to contemplate your crimes and are ready for penance?"

"—that happens."



## 6.

“Albert!” I hissed quickly as he scurried up to a standing position, and Neil began touring through our little makeshift captive camp. “Albert, there’s still time. Don’t let him do this!”

Unfortunately, I was wasting my . . . well, okay, I don’t have real breath, so let’s say “words.” Albert was back in full submission mode. He all but scampered over to Neil, making the report that we were all here and thoroughly subjugated. The other players confirmed this, bewailing their fates at having put their trust in Lord Drake instead of the clear superiority of Emperor Nikolai. The only exceptions to this were Lord Drake himself, Maria, and me. Lord Drake and Maria out of some sense of fictional, generic vampire pride, and me because I knew kissing ass was going to be a pointless gesture. Otherwise, I would have puckered up with the best of them.

Neil held up a hand, and everyone fell silent. “My poor, misguided subjects, your Emperor has had time to cool his head and give thought to what you’ve done. While I am hurt that you would try to tear me from my throne, I am also complimented that a faction as powerful as your own would consider me a threat. Therefore, I am going to give you all a second chance.”

There was a murmur of happiness that ran through the crowd. It seems some of my fellow captives had been sincerely concerned he would kill off their characters. The irony was palpable.

“Now, my dear assistant Albert will help you all to form a circle around me. I am doing this so that I might hold a binding ceremony. I will be letting you all live, but your powers will be sealed until the next new moon. By then

I hope we can be on better terms than we are now, and you will use your gifts to aid my kingdom instead of work against it,” Neil said as he opened his book and began flipping through it.

Albert was off like a flash, starting at the front and arranging us in a chained circle around Neil. It took relatively little time, since Albert was less helping more and just picking up and moving. There were some confused faces as the scrawny kid picked up large men like they weighed nothing, but after all, it was a night of magic and characters, so they let it slide.

Once again, I was last. As soon as Albert plucked me up, though, he whispered in my ear. “Listen, don’t worry, okay? Nothing bad will happen to you. Neil is out to steal life forces, and we dead guys don’t have that. Just sit through the ceremony, and you’ll be fine.”

“And everyone else?” I whispered out the side of my mouth.

“You’ll be fine,” Albert repeated a moment later, quickening his step and setting me down, thus finishing the circle of chained vampires.

It was a fairly wide circle, with plenty of room between each of us. I suppose Neil had wanted some room to work. I wondered how he would keep us in place once he started his spell if anyone decided to move about. My question was answered quickly as I saw Albert moving from person to person, wrapping their chains on each side around a tent stake, and then driving it into the earth. It took a few moments, even with his strength, but when he finished everyone but me would have found it impossible to put up even a half-hearted struggle.

The chains and stakes weren’t any sort of problem for me, though. No, I was even easier to stop. All Neil needed was three simple words, and I’d be exposed and powerless. I probably couldn’t even run away before he’d snap off his magical phrase and pin my ass down. Which meant my only options were to sit through the ceremony like Albert said, or wait until Neil was distracted and try to rush him. The thought of trying to fight someone, even a small geek like Neil, made my stomach turn a bit. At least I knew I couldn’t throw up thanks to Krystal.

For a moment, I thought my mind was playing tricks on me. No sooner

had I thought of Krystal than I saw her walking into the clearing. A moment later I noticed Charlie Brown ghost guy, and finally the man in the werewolf mask. Now I was really confused.

“Well, my good players, I think it is time for me to break character and let you know what is really going on,” Neil said. “I’m afraid I lied earlier. None of you will be leaving this circle alive.”

“We are already the proud and powerful dead!” Lord Drake shouted from his spot in the circle. I could see Maria nodding her head violently in agreement, and the rest of the vampire characters joined in with some show of support.

“You are NOT!” Neil thundered from the center of his circle. “You are sad people living a sad life playing a sad game to escape the misery of reality. The only person in this forest with any real power is myself. Behold, I’ve expanded my spell library and learned to take over the minds of the living.” Neil held his hands and indicated to the three people behind him. “These three each came to me as individuals with thoughts and dreams. Tonight I turned them into nothing more than puppets for my enjoyment.”

I really wasn’t comfortable with the way his eyes lingered on Krystal when he said “enjoyment.” I tried taking some deep breaths out of habit to calm my stomach. It was looking more and more like our only chance of getting out of here would be if I could rush him fast enough. Behind my back, I gently snapped through a few links of chain.

“I am a god among men, and you are nothing but painted-up children playing pretend,” Neil continued, sneering as he talked, no longer able to hide his sense of superiority. The players were beginning to get a little antsy. He had broken character a long time ago, yet he still seemed intent on doing them harm. A few even tested their bonds, realizing for the first time just how helpless they had really become.

“Tonight, however, your pitiful lives will have meaning,” Neil said as he began flipping through his book once more. “Tonight your souls, your life essence, will be used as a catalyst to fuel my own power. As your life flows into me, it will gain the purpose it lacked all these years with all of you. It is a

beautiful trade, don't you agree? You trade your lives, and in exchange you gain the fulfillment of having helped this city's next ruler rise to his position."

The players were panicking now; you'd have had to be an idiot not to see how drunk on his own magic Neil had become. Some were flexing violently against their chains. Others seemed to be crying and giving in to whatever this mad child had planned for them. I just kept my eyes trained on Neil and worked my way through the chains, bit by bit. I probably wouldn't have a chance until he began reading his spell.

"But enough chatter. I'm anxious to begin my life as a super being, and I'm sure you are all anxious to help. Minions!" Neil called. The three behind him stood at attention. "You will surround me now. Should anyone break free somehow, your job will be to restrain them until I am able to finish my spell. Let nothing disturb your exalted master!"

The three followed his orders instantly, forming a tight triangle around him so that no angle of entry would go unseen. They stared out at us, revolving slowly to keep fresh eyes on each prisoner as they turned. No one would get bored; no one would let something slip. Credit where it was due. I had to admit Neil had not fallen into the villain trope of overconfidence, even if he had monologued his evil plan.

"Well, this just sucks," I muttered, still breaking through the chains but with less enthusiasm. I had enough trouble getting my mind around the idea of trying to charge Neil head on. I didn't know how I was going to get through an innocent puppet without hurting them, especially if that puppet happened to be my date. I watched her as she moved: smooth, definite, without hesitation. In that moment, I could clearly see how she was an agent that dealt with supernatural beings. The girl had some physical training, which only served to make my job harder.

"Ah, here it is," Neil said, stopping his turning and lighting up his face with a terrifying smile. "Goodbye, mortality. *Oncidentum, rapishadum, GHAAAA!*"

For the record, that last line wasn't part of the spell. The moment he had begun chanting, I had snapped through the remainder of my chains and

sprung to my feet as fast as my vampire abilities would allow. As it turned out, though, even a hopped up vampire takes longer to stand than it takes for a trained agent to withdraw and utilize a taser. Into his crotch. And hold it there.

“Three things, shithead,” Krystal said as she released the taser, and Neil fell to the ground. “First off, you are under arrest for use of necromancy magic without a license. Secondly, never monologue. It gives away your intentions and gives everyone else time to prepare. Lastly, magic is fantastic, but it’s no match for my wand of brain shocking.” With that she knelt down and gave him one last blast to the chest. Neil was out, and I mean “out” as in “drooling and twitching out.” The other two puppets, unfortunately, seemed to be still carrying out orders. They rushed at Krystal, attacking the woman who had broken their master’s commandment.

She whipped around quickly, tripping the werewolf with her leg and slamming it with her taser as it tried to get up. The werewolf dropped like a hammer, and Krystal quickly turned expecting the ghost to be attacking her other side. What she found instead, though, was me holding the ghost by its hips horizontally over my head.

“I thought you might need a hand,” I said in what I hoped was a lighthearted manner.

“My hero,” Krystal replied with a grin. She ambled over, pulled off the ghost’s sheet and put the taser into the arm of the young woman who had been beneath it. The struggling over my head ceased, and I gently set down the girl, rolling up her costume and putting it under her head as a pillow.

This all sounds like a peaceful ballet of coordinated movements, but it was amid the screaming, shock, and crying of the other vampire prisoners. All of this was topped off by a wail from Albert, and he rushed forward and cradled Neil’s head.

“You killed him! You killed my friend!” Albert moaned.

“Did not,” Krystal said, ignoring the calls of the prisoners surrounding her and walking back over to the unconscious mage and the grieving zombie. “Anyone who can use magic has a slight resistance to all forms of energy. That includes electricity. It just required three bursts to take him down like it

would a normal person. He's fine, or at least he will be once he wakes up."

"But, he's under arrest," Albert said, worry thick in his voice. "Won't he be killed once he gets charged with what he tried to do tonight?"

"Don't be an idiot," Krystal said. "Ceremonies aren't illegal. I'm only charging him with magic usage without a license. You have to be trained and certified to do magic out in the open like this."

"Oh," Albert said, relief washing over his face.

"Truth be told, you should be worried more about yourself than your friend," Krystal said as she knelt down and picked up Neil's book. "Zombies are only allowed to exist on work visas."

"What does that mean?" Albert asked.

"Zombies need a job, or they lose focus and create havoc. Your buddy here is unlicensed, so he can't offer you employment. It's almost impossible for zombies to get work other than with the necromancer that created them, so we have to terminate them," Krystal explained.

"And when you say 'terminate' . . ." Albert let the sentence trail off.

"'Return you to your place in natural world' is the way the higher ups put it," she said, finishing his thought.

"Oh, no," Albert said, shaking slightly, despite the lack of any biological need to.

It was a heartbreaking night for the poor kid. He thought his only friend was dead, he discovered he needed a job he wouldn't be able to get, and he found out he would likely wind up dead again. My empathy went out to the now not-as-upbeat zombie. He obviously had some self-worth issues, and he definitely needed to stand up for himself more, but it seemed like he really had a good heart. That was a set of circumstances I found all too easy to empathize with.

"Hold on, Krystal," I said, butting into the conversation. "Exactly what kind of tax benefits come from employing Undead Americans?"

## 7.

“This movie is god-awful,” I said, taking a handful of popcorn and crunching down.

“Mmhmm. That’s why I picked it. I knew no one else would be here,” Krystal said, gesturing to the empty theatre.

“That couldn’t have anything to do with the fact that it’s three in the morning. Or that this theatre doesn’t even do late night showings.”

“Hey, I promised you a movie, so I called in a favor.”

“Uh huh. One day we need to have a talk about you and your job and your favors,” I said with a mustering of authority.

“Did you want to do that tonight?” Krystal said, her eyes growing serious. There was a hardness there that worried me a bit. I might be the more powerful between the two of us, but I didn’t really think I was the stronger.

“Well . . . no, not tonight. I think we’ve had enough of your job for this evening,” I said, as I verbally scampered away from that previous authoritative tone.

“Oh, like it was all bad. You got a new assistant and roommate out of the deal,” Krystal said, her eyes softening and her usual smile dancing into place.

“I couldn’t let the kid just be put back in the ground. Besides, I really did need the help. Still, I guess now I’ll have to buy blood and animal corpses to keep us both fed,” I said.

“Zombies don’t eat flesh, Freddy,” Krystal corrected. “They don’t eat anything, not for nutrition. That’s what makes them perfect servants. They don’t need to eat, drink, or sleep. All they do is work, and in the case of

yours, file documents.”

“Wait,” I said. “The whole reason we went out there was reports of a late night lumbering figure and an increase in missing pets. If that wasn’t Albert, then who was it?”

“Neil,” she said as she turned her attention to the frankenbeast skulking on the screen. “I got a full confession out of him while you were getting Albert set up at your place. He was out at night practicing to try and bring Albert back. He would kill the pets, then try to revive them. The one time he succeeded he let the damn thing wander away, which means I get to spend tomorrow hunting for a freaking zombie rabbit.”

“That will be an annoyance. Won’t you have to wipe the memories or something of all the vampire characters that saw Neil lose it too?” I asked.

“Feh, I wish we had mind-wiping abilities. That would be sweet,” Krystal said. “No, we already had the cops that came and unchained them feed them a story. Neil was just some kid who went off his meds and was going to chop them up. Luckily, they had an undercover agent there in the form of me, and I was able to subdue him before he committed any real crimes.”

“What about when you said he was under arrest for magic without a license?”

“Playing to his delusion so he would come along more peacefully.”

“Oh,” I said. “Well, I guess that makes sense. You know, for all his faults, Neil really did seem to care about his friend, though. The whole reason he started this was to bring back his buddy.”

Krystal nodded. “He’s talented, and he got into it for the right reasons. He just went a little nutty. It happens to everyone without training. Part of the sentence will be enrolling him in courses with a master. In a few months, he’ll be able to control the megalomania and still use magic. Kid with his talent will probably be certified in a year or so.”

“Yeah, I wanted to ask you about that. If Neil is so good at magic, why didn’t his mind control spell work on you?”

“Pshh, no one tells me what to do,” she said with a wink.

“That seemed like a dodge,” I said.



“Very good, fang boy.” Krystal lifted up the armrest that separated our two seats. “Now, do you want to chase this topic and keep talking,” she said as she wrapped her arms around my shoulders and pulled herself onto my lap, “or do you want to make some use of this empty theatre?”

For the record, I knew this was another dodge. A more sophisticated one admittedly, but still, obviously, her changing the subject to avoid me asking more questions. I knew that quite clearly.

I just didn’t care. Relationships are built on trust anyway, right?

# A Weresteed at the Slots

## 1.

My girlfriend's truck had balls. Not literal ones, of course. These were chrome facsimiles that attached to the hitch. They looked strangely in place on her vehicle, which looked strangely in place enclosed around her as she drove me and my assistant down the sun-parched highway. It was a black pickup, enormous in size and decorated with polished chrome on the grill and interspersed periodically across the frame. She, on the other hand, was a medium-height blonde woman with muddy brown eyes, a low cut spaghetti-strap top, and faded blue jeans. If not for the gun strapped to her hip, she would have looked like the average southern belle. On second thought, I suppose the gun didn't disqualify her from fitting that stereotype.

"I'm still amazed by this glass," I said as I stared at the noonday sun from my seat on the passenger's side. A lesser man might have objected to the woman taking the wheel on such a long journey. A lesser man would also have been a stupider man, and one with a severe crotch injury to boot.

"Yeah, our R&D guys are something else," Krystal said, as she passed a motorist moving too slowly for her tastes, and by "too slowly," I mean "under ninety miles an hour."

"Assuredly. When did you get the glass put in anyway?"

"Oh, I've always had it. I'm something of a fang junkie so it only makes sense to keep it in my car."

"Ah . . . oh," I said. It was hardly surprising. Krystal worked for an

agency of the government that dealt with supernatural beings on a daily basis. It wasn't farfetched that she would be seduced by the confidence and power of a vampire. Not one like me—a more classic, suave vampire.

"It's a joke, Freddy. You're my first light-allergic boyfriend. I promise," Krystal said with a wide, cheerful grin.

We both had good reason to be happy. Krystal and I had reconnected at our high school reunion a few weeks back, amidst a pack of murderous werewolves, and had begun dating. It had taken some time, but a few days ago we had formalized our relationship as being committed. I suppose that doesn't sound like much, but when the majority of your mortal life was spent cuddling up to a tub of ice cream and a classic film, getting a girlfriend still held something of a primordial thrill.

"I'm just glad we get to come," chimed in Albert from the back.

"Of course, I wanted you guys to come," Krystal said. "This is Thanksgiving, after all. It'll be a nice change to eat with friends, instead of camped out in some motel room on a stakeout to figure out if the local murders are the work of a serial killer or a ghoul."

"We're glad to spend it with you," I said truthfully. This was my first Thanksgiving in years with other people, and I was all but brimming with joy in anticipation and appreciation. "Though I'm still not sure why we'll be spending it in Vegas."

"There aren't many of us Agents to go around, and when you take out the few who have managed to wrangle families along with their careers, it's even less of us. So while we get the holidays themselves off, we pretty much have to work right up until them. Besides, they have great restaurants, and I can't cook for shit."

"Right, but why Vegas?" I asked again.

"I used to do life counseling for parahumans who were having trouble," Krystal said. "One of my old clients called and asked me to come out and advocate for him. Apparently he got into trouble with the local dracolings."

"What's a dracoling?" Albert asked from the back. I was thankful he didn't know because the truth was I certainly didn't either.

“Dracolings are basically humans with dragon blood. They aren’t much physically stronger than mortals, but those bastards have a touch of magic and are sly as foxes when it comes to money. Not to mention they own all of the casinos in Las Vegas,” Krystal said, swerving past another motorist while throwing up the finger.

“That’s impossible,” I said. “Vegas is a town owned by many different corporations and investors. One group of people couldn’t possess all of it.”

“And no human would burn to a crisp just from a little sunlight. You want to crack open the door and see how things go?” Krystal asked.

“*Touché*,” I sighed as I admitted defeat. Living as a vampire and dealing with Krystal had forced me to re-evaluate my definitions of what was and wasn’t possible. It was rarely an enjoyable process to indulge in. “How exactly does this glass let in the light without reducing me to cinders?”

“Magic,” Krystal said simply. “I’d go more in depth, but I’m not an arcane specialist. All I know is that they enchant the glass, and my boyfriend can come along for the ride.”

“And his assistant,” Albert said, poking his face through ever-so-slightly from the backseat.

“And who could forget his charming assistant?” Krystal reassured him. Perhaps it was because of how he died or who he was, but Albert could be a bit insecure at times. Then again, I was the last person to be throwing stones in that regard.

“So these dracolings, they own all of Vegas somehow. What does that have to do with your client?” I asked.

“Bubba has a bit of a gambling problem.”

“Bubba?” I asked.

“Bubba?” Albert echoed.

“Bubba,” Krystal affirmed. “And I’ll thank you to be nice to him when you boys meet. He’s a good guy and a sweetheart. Aside from the gambling problem, he’s hardworking and responsible.”

“Sounds as though the gambling might have gotten ahead of the other stuff,” I said.

“It’s the damn holidays,” Krystal said. “If all you have is an addiction, then seeing everyone connecting with friends and family leaves you feeling lonely. So they run off to the only thing that seems to give them joy and validation. It’s a sad scenario, and I wish my agency was doing more to help it.”

“Why aren’t they?” I asked.

“Budget and manpower limitations. If we have to choose between putting down a revolution of mages or offering counseling to depressed pixies, guess where the funds end up?” Krystal said.

“I see,” I said. “So your friend Bubba was caught up in gambling, and these dracolings own Vegas, so I assume they acquired his debt?”

“More or less. Dracolings love gambling because they’re good at it. They have sharp minds and sharper senses, so it’s hard to get one past them,” Krystal said.

“If they’re so good, then why does anyone ever gamble with them?” I asked.

“Because they share their ancestor’s weakness as well as their strength.”

“They eat virgins?” Albert asked uncertainly.

“What? No. They can’t resist a bet. If you play for high enough stakes and can trick them into betting on something you know you will win, then you can make a fortune.”

“So, it’s like playing the lottery, except instead of risking a dollar, you basically risk everything you own,” I said.

“That’s not the worst analogy I’ve ever heard. Anyway, they have a lot of treaties with my agency, and there’s respect for us, so if I go in and advocate for Bubba, I should be able to at least get him on some sort of payment plan.”

“I’m guessing I don’t want to know what the other option for him is,” I said.

“Smart man. The other option is he works for them at minimum wage until he pays off his debt,” Krystal said.

“He could always declare bankruptcy.” Albert’s voice was raised slightly, and there was a touch of pride in his tone. I had been teaching him some basic

financial terms, and it seemed he was anxious to show he had listened.

“That works with human debt, but dracolings have special provisions that allow them to enslave people who are indebted to them,” Krystal said. “It’s actually not so far off from what happened with the Native American treaties as far as cultural preservation, though dracolings had much better leverage and representation.”

“What was there leverage?” I asked.

“Same as their representation. They called in a great grandparent to negotiate for them. Those negotiators agreed to help in the country’s war efforts in exchange for certain privileges. The result was that the dracolings got special areas with limited government interference and the right to keep their customs and traditions alive without sanction,” Krystal said.

“Help with the war? This must have been a long time ago, was it World War One?”

“Las Vegas existed way before that, dear,” Krystal said. “It’s actually been around for centuries, though it didn’t go the way of glitz and glamour until the last fifty years or so when that became the best money-making campaign.”

“For centuries . . . was it the civil war?” I tried again.

“Still too late. Parahumans were actually forced to align with the North during the Civil War, since their treaties and contracts were with the United States of America, and that’s the title that the North retained. It’s one of the reasons Lincoln knew he could win if the South seceded.”

“Huh . . .” I sighed. “The things they leave out of the history books.”

“In defense of ‘them,’ we’re the ones who ordered those things to stay out of books,” Krystal said.

“‘We’ being your employer,” I said.

“Bingo,” Krystal affirmed.

“How long has your non-existent little agency non-existed?” I asked.

“Since the beginning,” she said. “We were formed at the same time the treaties and agreements with the various supernatural groups were so that we could police and enforce those contracts.”

“Wait a minute,” Albert said, leaning up from the backseat. “When you say ‘since the beginning,’ do you mean . . . ?”

“It was a good deal all around. The supernatural creatures wanted a country where they had rights as citizens, and the founders of the country needed some way to drive back the superior numbers and might of the English.”

“Are you telling me that vampires and werewolves are the reason America won the Revolutionary War?” I asked, dumbfounded.

“No, I’m saying America somehow managed to pull it out thanks to the French,” Krystal scoffed.

There was a beat of silence, then Albert said: “You know, when you think about it, her version makes a lot more sense.”

I shook my head. “The things you think you know.”

“Be proud, Freddy, there were powerful vampires in that war,” Krystal said. “They eliminated entire British platoons in a single night, saving the lives of American soldiers and civilians in the process.”

“Yeah . . . but still,” I said. “It’s a lot to take in.”

“I tell you what—once we get done with the business with Bubba and our Thanksgiving, I’ll request clearance to show you a few files. I think getting in touch with your vampire heritage will do a lot for your pride as an Undead American,” Krystal said with a gentle tone I had forgotten she could use.

“That sounds surprisingly nice,” I said. “You think things with Bubba and the dracolings will be that easy to deal with?”

“I’m sure of it,” Krystal said.

One day, one beautiful and glorious day, I will stop listening when she says things like that. One day, but that night was not the day.

## 2.

“Okay, boys, the name of today’s game is called keep your mouth shut,” Krystal said as we took a seat at a long conference table. We had checked into our hotel, Excalibur, upon arriving and were told to come straight to the meeting room. Our bags were swept away, and we were hustled down the hall into a pleasant looking room that seemed suspiciously absent of cameras or windows. Krystal had attempted to protest that neither Albert nor I were a part of the meeting; however, the security said everyone who arrived with her had to show up, and do so immediately. She hadn’t even been allowed to change into her business-appropriate attire; instead, she was stuck to attending her meeting in dusty jeans and a red tank top. Thus she was giving us a quick rundown in what we were to do during her meeting, which essentially consisted of not speaking a damn word.

“I’ll talk to Morgan as soon as he comes in, but there is a chance you two will have to sit through the whole meeting. Dracolings can be odd about some things, and he might see you two as necessary additions just because you’re with me. If that’s the case, then stay quiet no matter what,” she said.

“I don’t think either of us would have anything to add anyway,” I said.

“You think that now but . . . look, dracolings don’t like when things change. They’ve been holding on to the same traditions for millennia. They might say something or do something that seems offensive to you modern guys. Deal with it. You have to stay quiet. Working with dracolings requires a two year long certification process that has to be renewed annually. That’s how complicated interacting with them is.”



“That seems a bit excessive,” I said.

“These are a people who have government protected rights to do things as their traditions dictate regardless of certain laws. Additionally, they are shrewd gamblers and place a tremendous amount of emphasis on a person’s honor. Anything that is said to them is taken as a legally binding commitment. A poorly-timed joke could cost you your entire life savings. Still seem excessive?”

“Can I go to the room?” Albert asked. He was fidgeting and biting gently on his lower lip. I didn’t blame him, Krystal had put a generous amount of fear into me too with her explanation.

“Hopefully, yes,” Krystal said. “But if not, just remember to stay quiet. You can’t make any mistakes if you don’t say anything.”

She likely had more to tell us, but at that moment it became too late. The doors opened, and four men walked into the room. Three of them wore suits that were clearly custom tailored by master craftsmen. Jewelry adorned them in ways that seemed just a touch elaborate on men, and each moved with an oddly fluid grace and supreme confidence. In one glance, I knew they owned this room, this building, and everything their eyes surveyed. These were leaders, men who would have been kings in another time and place. As they sat down across from us, folding themselves into the high-backed leather chairs, I finally tore my gaze from them and looked at the other man who had entered the room.

He looked . . . different. This man stood at least a foot taller than the dracolings, and likely a hundred or so pounds heavier. His broad frame was clothed by a short-sleeved plaid shirt and a pair of jeans. A baseball cap hid his hair, but a pair of surprisingly kind eyes peered out from its brim. His bulk was primarily muscle, though a gut did betray that at least some of his lifestyle was unhealthy. He gave a big grin and a small wave to Krystal, then took a seat a few spaces apart from the dracolings.

“Pleasant evening, Enforcer Jenkins,” said the middle dracoling, an older man with jet black hair.

“Pleasant evening, Lord Ackers,” Krystal said. She seemed composed,

but colder than normal. Krystal always seemed to have a devil-may-care attitude about her, trusting her skill and smarts to see her through any trouble that life could dish out. That was absent now; in its place were careful eyes and conservative body language. It was a very peculiar shift, and one that made me realize how much I preferred the everyday version of her.

“Before we begin our discussion on Mr. Emerson’s debt to you, I would like to request permission to speak with you on a matter pertaining to the meeting itself,” Krystal said.

The black-haired dracoling, Lord Ackers I suppose, leaned back in his chair a moment and appeared to genuinely consider it. It seemed like a simple request to me, but I noticed the other dracolings looking at him anxiously. It was beginning to dawn on me that Krystal hadn’t elaborated when she talked about how serious tradition and honor was when talking to these people.

“I will permit your request, on the condition that we may address each other informally,” Lord Ackers said. “We have met together many times, and I see no reason why we should not be able to be familiar with one another.”

Krystal hesitated for a moment, then nodded. “I agree, Morgan. You and I have had dealings before.”

“Excellent, Krystal. I prefer engendering comfort with those I work with regularly,” Morgan said. Funny thing though, Krystal didn’t seem more comfortable now that they were using first names. If anything, I was picking up more signs of stress from her body. I hoped that dracolings sight, hearing, and smell weren’t on par with my own.

“Now, what would you like to speak of?” Morgan asked her.

“I would like to formally request that my two attendants be sent back to the hotel room,” Krystal said. “They are not affiliated with the Agency, and as such do not have clearance to be present at this meeting.”

“Why not? The one wearing false glasses is a vampire, and the one wearing a T-shirt is a zombie. Both of them are parahumans and therefore are allowed to know of others of their kind,” Morgan said. It was a bit creepy that he knew what Albert and I both were, and even that my glasses were fake. I didn’t need to still wear them after I was turned, but I had been donning a pair

of frames since my childhood. My face didn't feel right without them.

"What you speak is true. However, this meeting involves the financial status of another person and his arrangement with you. Those are things that are considered private and those not involved would not be privy to such information," Krystal countered.

"Yes, but the privacy control is all on our end," Morgan said with a small grin. "If I have no objection to their presence, then there is no legal need for them to vacate the room."

I braced for Krystal to tell him to shut up and just let us out of the damn meeting already. She wasn't known for her patience and an argument about keeping non-essential people here had to be taxing her limits. I was sure at any moment she would be lighting into this smug, suit-wearing jerk.

"You are correct, Morgan. I thank you for hearing my humble request. The matter has been satisfactorily concluded," she said. I don't think I kept much of the shock off my face. Krystal being subservient at all, let alone to this degree, was mind blowing.

"Good," Morgan said. "Now we move onto the matter of Mr. Emerson's debt. As of today he owes us four hundred ninety-two thousand, eight hundred and sixty-two dollars. We have stopped counting the cents and begun rounding to the nearest dollar for convenience's sake."

"Four . . . hundred . . . *thousand*?" Krystal asked. Though her words were direct to Morgan, her eyes were digging straight into Bubba. I had seen those eyes before, and clearly Bubba had as well since he was avoiding her gaze and looking very thoroughly ashamed. The man had every physical advantage over her, but it was evident he had a healthy amount of fear from this thin blonde woman, which only showed that he was much smarter than his name would indicate.

"Four hundred ninety-two thousand, eight hundred and sixty-two dollars, actually," Morgan corrected her. "As you know this is well above the level where we are allowed to place him into our custody until he has worked off the debt. Additionally, he has passed the point where there is any legal recourse to adjust his debt or payment."

“I am aware of this now,” Krystal said slowly. “Though, when Mr. Emerson requested my presence, it was with the indication that I would be acting as advocate. In matters of over two hundred thousand, it is well known that no outside entity holds any authority to alter the decisions of the dracoling who holds that debt. I am a touch confused as to why, then, Mr. Emerson asked me to come all the way out here.”

“I cannot speak to that,” Morgan said. “I do not claim to understand what goes on in Mr. Emerson’s mind. However, I took your meeting because we strive to be in compliance with all clauses of our treaty with your government, and to try and foster good relations between we two.”

“I thank you for accepting my meeting, and your good will is noted and will be reported. In the spirit of such good will, I have another boon to ask of you, Morgan, since it seems our meeting will be coming to a swift end. I would like to request that Mr. Emerson be permitted to tell both you and I why he felt it necessary to draw us both into a meeting with no possibility of resolution,” Krystal said in a strained voice. Her eyes were dead set on Bubba, who for his part seemed more resigned than nervous about his problematic situation.

“I daresay that would play directly into what he was hoping for,” Morgan said. “I am not in the habit of aiding those who seek to waste my valuable time and resources.”

“I would consider it a high token of friendship between your people and the Agency,” Krystal said slowly, pronouncing every syllable with care and consideration. Given what she had told us, speaking on behalf of her office must have been something exceedingly dangerous.

“Well, then, I would be a fool not to offer such a token,” Morgan said, his grin deepening noticeably. “Mr. Emerson, you may speak with Krystal on the topic of why you called in an advocate on this case.”

“I didn’t call in an advocate,” Bubba said, a snarky tone and southern twang reverberating in the strong bass of his voice. “I called in my friend.”

Bubba turned his body and met Krystal’s gaze. “I knew as soon as I lost my last bet that it was over. I just wanted to tell you goodbye in person. You

were a lot of help to me after I lost Mom and Dad, and you helped keep me on the right track for a long time. You're the only person left in this world to miss me, and I just wanted to thank you for what you did. You're one of the few that cares, and I didn't want you to think you had failed me somehow when you heard about this. I wanted you to know that if you hadn't been there, I would have wound up in a much worse place much sooner. So, Krystal, for everything you did and for all the people I know you're going to go on to help, thank you from the bottom of my heart."

Bubba stood from his chair and looked back at the dracolings. "Okay, shitheads, we can go now."

"That concludes our meeting," Morgan said to Krystal as he rose. "I hope you enjoy your stay at the hotel, and please feel free to call on me if you have any other issues that need discussion." The other dracolings echoed his movements, and all four men began heading for the door.

"Wait!" Krystal yelled. She stood up from her chair and knocked it back. Her eyes were sparking and her jaw was set. This was a Krystal I was more familiar with. This was the Krystal who was about to whip some ass.

"I invoke the right to challenge for the debt of Bubba Emerson," she declared.

That's pretty much when all hell broke loose.

### 3.

Bubba bellowed out a powerful “NO!” and leapt forward. Before he had taken two steps, one of the dracolings touched his shoulder and Bubba dropped to the ground in wild spasms. Krystal . . . well, there’s no other way to say it . . . . Krystal growled gutturally and leapt to Bubba’s shaking side. The other dracoling pulled Morgan away and stood between him and a now clearly pissed-off Krystal. Albert, meanwhile, let out a squeak and dropped from his chair to hide under the table. I desperately wanted to follow suit, but a part of me was screaming that if I dropped down and didn’t keep my eyes trained on the altercation, there was a very good chance I would soon be single again. I knew I was physically stronger than everyone else in the room, but that didn’t mean much when just the yelling was making me feel skittish.

It was Morgan who broke the silence: “Enforcer Jenkins, given Mr. Emerson’s outburst and the sudden commotion, I am willing to acquiesce that I may not have heard you correctly. Would you be so kind as to repeat yourself?”

“I demand the right to challenge for the debt of Bubba Emerson,” Krystal said softly as she held Bubba’s shoulder while his twitching subsided.

“Acknowledged,” Morgan said. “You are aware that, as a woman, you are ineligible to challenge in our traditional manner?”

“I am,” Krystal agreed.

“Then we shall conduct the match using our secondary method. You may follow me,” Morgan said, straightening his suit and not quite hiding the greedy glint in his eye.

“I request our stakes be held in escrow,” Krystal said, rising slowly from Bubba’s side.

Morgan nodded. “That is your right as well. Bubba Emerson shall stay with your attendants, but they shall remain within this casino. Are those conditions acceptable?”

“They are,” Krystal said. “I will instruct my attendants on the handling of our stakes, and then we may begin the match.”

“Acceptable.” Morgan took a step back and waited against the wall. His attendants followed his cue, leaving the massive, dropped body of Bubba alone in the center of the floor.

Krystal hurried over to me. “This shouldn’t take long, so as soon as Bubba wakes up, get him down to the restaurant. That shock will have taken a lot out of him, so get some food in him fast. I should be able to join you guys within the hour.”

“I would very much like to be told what is going on,” I said in a hushed whisper.

“I know, sweetie,” Krystal said kindly. “And Bubba will fill in the gaps when he comes around. Just have some faith that I know what I’m doing till then, okay?”

“Of course. We’ll take care of him, but please join us soon.”

“No problem,” she said with her usual, confident grin. It was picture perfect, the heartwarming familiar image of Krystal about to lay waste to some unsuspecting fool who had dared to take her on. If only I hadn’t heard her heart rate jump, or smelled the surge of fear that ran through her, I might have been able to be comforted.

Sometimes being a vampire really blows.

## 4.

“It’s an ancient rite,” Bubba said as he began doing considerable damage to the steak that was resting innocently in front of him. I had hauled Bubba downstairs and found shelter in one of the buffets. It had taken him half an hour to come around, and as soon as he did, he had leapt up and sworn he would tear Morgan limb from limb. After that it took us another ten minutes to calm him down somewhat when he realized Krystal had gone through with the challenge. Once we finally convinced him it was happening, he’d agreed to fill in Albert and me, but only after visiting the buffet table.

“Basically,” Bubba continued, “those who are equal or better to the one enslaved may challenge for the ownership of the debt. If the challenger wins, they get the debt and the slave is either set free or serves ’em. If the dracolings win, the challenger is assigned a debt equal to the original slave’s, and they get enslaved, too.”

“So, Krystal just put her freedom on the line for you?” I had known something was up, but I had never imagined it went this deep.

“Yup,” Bubba said. “Which is why you shoulda stopped her, dammit! I didn’t call her down here to get caught up in my mess. I just wanted to say goodbye to someone who mattered, and that’s a short list.”

“I didn’t know.” Even to my ears, it seemed a lame defense. “Besides, have you ever seen anyone stop Krystal from doing something she was set on? Ever?”

“Well . . . no,” Bubba admitted. “But that don’t mean you can’t try.”

“I’m sorry.” Albert was fidgeting with the pile of peas on his plate, not making eye contact with either of us. “Krystal had said how cunning they were, and when things got bad, I just panicked. I should have tried to stop her, too.”

There was something oddly disarming about Albert’s apology. It brought how helpless we had all truly been into glaring light.

“It ain’t your fault,” Bubba said. “If it’s anybody’s fault, it’s mine. I know



that girl. I should have known she'd pull something crazy like this the minute I got her involved. I was being a self-absorbed jackass, and now she's in danger."

"What kind of danger?" I asked. "All they said was something about a match. What's happening right now, anyway?"

"Dracolings are big on tradition," Bubba said. "So they only have two forms of trials. Since Krystal's a girl, she'll be doing the one for those they don't consider to be warriors. They're playing a game of chess right now."

"Chess? That's it? I thought she'd be fighting a bear with a stick or something, from how serious everyone was," I said.

"I think I'd rather she was fighting the bear. At least then we'd know she'd be okay."

"Yeah, Krystal would come back with a new rug." Albert chuckled. It was pretty hard to imagine anything, animal or otherwise, getting the best of Krystal in a fight.

"So . . . what if she loses?" I didn't want to ask, but it seemed pointless to ignore the possibility.

"If she loses, she becomes bound to them, something they own. That means she works for them, does whatever they say, and is susceptible to their magic," Bubba told us.

"Is that what they did to you earlier?" Albert asked.

"Yeah, the fuckers could have just frozen me in my tracks, but dropping me like a sack of rotten potatoes is also an option they have," Bubba said.

"Why would they take the bet, though? As an Agent, Krystal has training, experience, and cunning. Plus, she hung out with the chess team in high school. Doesn't that seem like a bad bet to the dracolings?" I asked, though I didn't bother explaining the point of how I knew she had hung with the chess team in high school. I did say we once ran in similar social circles, after all.

"Dracolings take all kinds of bets, usually because they have an ace up their sleeve," Bubba said. "I promise you whoever she's playing is a chess master. That aside, if she loses that means they own an Agent. Dracolings

love power, connections, and leverage. Having someone they own in the Agency is a payoff they couldn't pass up the chance on—forget the odds.”

“So, they think they can win,” I said.

“They *know* they can win. They always know they can win. That certainty is probably their only weakness. The only way to beat them is to come totally out of left field.”

“If anyone can do that, Krystal can,” Albert said with force.

“Damn right,” Bubba agreed.

“She is something amazing,” I said. “How did you two meet, anyway?”

“I lost my parents when I was young and fell in with a couple of rough kids from the neighborhood. Weresteeds don't get much respect from the outset in the supernatural community, and I was kind of an exceptional case even in that regard,” Bubba told us.

“Weresteed?” Albert asked.

“Yeah, I turn into a horse.”

“Okay, hang on,” I said. “I sort of get the werewolves thing. But horses? How does that even work? Horses don't bite people. Where would werehorses have originally come from?”

“Weresteeds.” Bubba's tone was surprisingly firm as he corrected me. “And no, we don't bite people. It's passed on through lineage like lots of other kinds of supernatural abilities. As for where we came from, I have no idea.”

“You don't?” I asked.

“Do you know how vampires were created?” Bubba shot back.

“I suppose I don't, actually.”

“Exactly. Parahumans ain't that special. We get to wonder about the origins of our kind just like the humans do. Maybe some of the really old ones might have an inklin' or two, but if anyone knows for sure, they ain't talking.”

“I guess that does make sense.” I said.

“I know where I came from,” Albert announced.

“You know the source and details of the magic that pumps through your body, keeping your undead but moving?” Bubba asked.

“Oh . . . no,” Albert said.

“You see what I mean,” Bubba said, polishing off the last of his steak. “Anyway, the point was that weresteeds don’t get much respect, so I was working triple hard to make a street name for myself. I got busted one night, and Krystal was the one they sent down to deal with me. Instead of just beating me down, or putting me in a cage, she took an interest in me. She got me a part-time job, found me a real place to stay, and helped get me on my feet. If not for Krystal, I’d still be some idiot kid on the streets.”

“That’s pretty ama . . . zi . . . ” I trailed off as a familiar scent hit my nostrils. Within moments I had picked out the footsteps that corresponded to the smell I’d noted and could tell they were coming toward us. “Company,” I said. Albert stiffened, and Bubba cracked his knuckles.

The dracoling, one of Morgan’s nameless attendants, glided up to our table showing no surprise that we were waiting for him.

“Gentlemen, if you will accompany me to the conference room. The match is done, and it is time for the winner to claim their prize.” With that the dracoling turned and began heading out of the restaurant.

“Do we go?” Albert asked.

“No option,” Bubba said as he finished a long draw of tea from his glass. “You heard him. It’s time to settle up. Let’s just hope things came out in our favor.”

## 5.

Filtering back into the room felt odd. Things had been so hurried and wild when we left, yet when we entered the room, it was quiet and calm. Morgan and his attendants sat on the same side of the table, hands crossed and neutral expressions on their faces. The only blatant difference in the room was that Krystal was sitting on the same side of the table as the dracolings. Before I smelled her, before I heard her heartbeat, before I even saw her face, that fact alone told me all I needed to know.

“You lost,” I said simply. I hadn’t even made it to my chair. Albert, Bubba, and I were still near the door. I probably should have just walked in and taken a seat. I know I should have let Bubba do all the talking since he was already in deep. But I didn’t. Instead, I blurted out those words because I didn’t want to dance around the truth. I needed to know, right then and right there, standing by that doorway.

“Perceptive,” Morgan said. “But not surprising for one of your ilk. Yes, Enforcer Jenkins did not triumph in her match and is now one of my belongings.”

The word “belongings” grated against something inside of me. I couldn’t tell you what it was because it felt raw and hard, and those were things I wasn’t accustomed to discovering in myself. Bubba apparently echoed my sentiment, though, as I heard his knuckles crack behind me.

“Now, now, no need for posturing,” Morgan said with a slimy smile. “Mr. Emerson is already under our power, and while you two gentlemen do possess more physical strength than us, I think you will find Enforcer Jenkins and Mr. Emerson harmed quite brutally should you attempt to escalate our little confrontation.”

I could feel Bubba’s tense body slacken. I doubted he had any concern for his own safety, but if they were going to hurt Krystal, then he wouldn’t fight back. As for me, the idea of throwing a fit hadn’t even occurred to me. I had an entirely different backup plan ready for this situation.

“I demand the right to challenge for the debt of Krystal Jenkins and Bubba Emerson,” I stated loudly.

Hell didn’t really break loose this time. Krystal did gasp, and Bubba seemed a touch surprised, but the dracolings only laughed at me.

“You are a silly little vampire, aren’t you?” Morgan asked. “First off, you are not an Agent nor a knight, so you have no rights to challenge. Secondly, you cannot challenge for the debt of two slaves. One warrior, one slave—that is the way the bets are structured.”

“What if he doubled up?” Albert said.

Morgan raised an eyebrow. “Explain.”

“Fred will bet his freedom . . . and mine. It will be one battle, but if he wins, he gets both slaves. If you win, then you get two new slaves. The rules are the same. We’re just raising the stakes,” Albert said, not without some hesitation.

“You can’t do that,” I whispered.

“And you can? Fred, if I can’t work for you, then they’ll put me back in the ground anyway. You doing this is an unlife or death bet for me regardless. At least like this maybe they’ll take it.”

“You gentlemen are aware we can hear you, correct?” Morgan asked. “And while I do find the raising of stakes acceptable, I still have no reason to take the bet. Neither of you can demand a challenge, so it must be agreed on to be accepted. Yes, gaining two undead servants would have some use to us, but nowhere near as great as ownership of an Agent. The potential gain is simply not great enough to justify the potential loss.”

“Well, if it sweetens the pot any, I do own my own accounting agency. Maybe I could be used to help with the books,” I said in desperation. It was a stupid long shot. I was under no illusions that the dracolings would actually find a vampire a more desirable bet because he was an accountant.

As it turned out, I was dead wrong in that assumption. It was like I’d jolted each of the dracolings with electricity, the way they reacted when I mentioned the word “accounting.”

“You are . . . an accountant?” Morgan asked.

“Um, yes. I run my own business out of my apartment, and I do pretty good work,” I said.

“Do you know how difficult it is to find a parahuman that is both capable and willing to balance books?” Morgan asked me again.

“I’m sure there are plenty of humans who are glad for the work,” I said.

“Humans, bah!” Morgan said. “Due to secrecy agreements in our treaties, we can never reveal to them what we are, so any expenses incurred that relate to our nature must be hidden from them, forcing us to do the work ourselves.”

“So, if you won Fred, you wouldn’t have to do that anymore,” Albert said. “You would finally have a parahuman who could all of the numbers work for you.”

“Indeed,” Morgan said. “May I ask your full name, vampire?”

“Fredrick Frankford Fletcher.”

“Well, Mr. Fletcher, in light of your occupation, I will admit that I do find this bet to be enticing,” Morgan said. “It is accepted; however, our champion is currently out of the casino this evening. Would you be willing to wait until tomorrow morning to have your match?”

“How are they out of the casino?” I asked. “Krystal just had her match.”

Morgan chuckled. “Mr. Fletcher, Enforcer Jenkins had a match with me, which was a game of chess. It is the trial used for women, since they are not strong enough to endure a man’s trial. As a man, you will of course be doing battle in our traditional form.”

Krystal had warned me they were stuck in the past. “Wait, so I won’t be playing chess?” I’d been something of a chess champion in my youth, and I still played online to keep my mind fresh. I had been certain I could handle anything some dracoling could throw at me on the checked battlefield. If that wasn’t the contest, though, my confidence was somewhat lower. And by “somewhat,” I mean “extremely.”

“You will do battle with our champion in the manner of the only true adversaries that our dragon ancestors ever faced. Of all the menaces in the land, only knights conducted themselves with the honor, strength, and determination that allowed our ancestors to acknowledge them as worthy

warrior combatants. As such, since we dracolings cannot do battle in the way of the dragons, our trial is the one that the knights themselves used,” Morgan said.

“Okay, so just so we’re all on the same page here, what did I just sign up for?” I asked.

“At tomorrow morning you will be battling our champion in a joust,” Morgan said. “You may have access to our stables and equipment until then to prepare as needed. You also may use any steed on the premises, with of course the exception of the grey mare that our champion rides. Be in the stables at seven sharp ready to compete.”

“What about Krystal? Do we get to keep her in escrow?”

“You have no more neutral parties to entrust her to. All of you are involved in this wager,” Morgan said. “Therefore, she will stay at my casino under my attendant’s watchful eye. Since Mr. Emerson’s debt is still in question, our previous agreement to escrow remains valid, and he may stay with you. See you in the morning, Mr. Fletcher.” With that he gave us a wave toward the door. I looked at Krystal before turning around, something I hadn’t dared to do the entire time I had spoken with Morgan, for fear she would somehow talk me out of it.

When I did meet her eyes at last, I was nearly knocked back. Her eyes were all but screaming at me, her face contorted in frustration as she tried to communicate. I had known Krystal for a long time in my youth, and I had seen much of her since we reconnected, and I knew one thing for certain. Krystal could have never restrained her mouth if she felt that strongly about something, which only left one option . . . . They had used their magic to render her silent.

Terrified as I was, I turned on my heel and strode out as powerfully as I could. There was no way I would let these bastards know I was shaking in my comfortable brown loafers.

## 6.

“You really screwed the pooch on this one,” Bubba said once we were comfortably far from the conference room and heading toward the stables. Though it would be foolish to assume the dracolings wouldn’t have eyes and ears on every inch of their property, there was no sense in making our conversations easier for them to overhear.

“Maybe it will be okay,” I said, more out of desperate hope than actual optimism. “I mean a joust is sort of a physical event, and I am a lot stronger than humans.”

“A joust is closer to a shooting match than a fight,” Bubba corrected. “You have to aim your lance at a precise spot to try and topple your opponent, while steering your horse at just the right pace and keeping your balance, all while dodging the lance heading straight for you. The only place strength really comes in is in lifting the damn lance, which I’m sure you’ll do great at.”

We reached the gaming floor then, and after some quick directions from an attendant, headed to the arena. Evidently, Morgan had already called down and alerted everyone to our new level of clearance because as we left the casino area and stepped into Excalibur’s arena, not one worker stopped or bothered us. In fact, a pair of well-muscled men wearing suits specifically let us into the arena, then locked the doors after we stepped through. We kept silent as we moved during this time, even Albert, because the last thing we wanted was for everyone to see that we knew how good and screwed we were.

“It still doesn’t seem hopeless,” Albert said once the doors had been secured behind us. “Vampires are more than strong; they also have enhanced coordination, reflexes, and speed.”

“The key word there is ‘enhanced,’” Bubba said as we walked through the spacious tournament floor. There were stadium seats that stretched far above us, and the ground beneath us was covered in dirt and straw. In the



center of one side of the seating was a boxed off area adorned with curtains and jewels, with a pair of thrones resting inside of it.

“If Fred had been some sort of fighter, or athlete, or anything like that before he got turned, then we might be a little better off,” Bubba continued. “But given that he’s wearing glasses and a sweater vest AFTER becoming a vamp, I’m guessing he wasn’t much of a tough guy when he had a heartbeat.”

They both paused and looked at me, at which point I did my best to look inconspicuous. It wasn’t as though I could really debate Bubba on that point.

“He still got enhanced, though,” Albert said.

“And if I multiply ten by two, I get twenty. Much higher than two, but not as good as if I’d multiplied ten by ten and gotten a hundred,” Bubba said. “Anyway, this is all pointless. Did you really think Morgan and his boys didn’t know vampires were stronger than dracolings? Dracolings always take bets they know they can win, so you can be damned sure there’s an ace in the hole.”

“What do you think it will be?” I asked.

“Oh, I don’t wonder. I already know what it is,” Bubba said. “Follow me.”

With that he began walking off across the arena, toward a set of large wooden doors near the rear. Albert and I kept pace, unsure of what to expect. Bubba reached the doors and threw them open with ease. He strode into a room that would have been dark to human eyes, though Albert and I could easily make out the horses resting comfortably in their stables. We ventured after him, and that’s when the world came tumbling down.

The moment my foot crossed the threshold of the dark room, a cacophony of screaming noise pierced my ears. Let me tell you something—having senses beyond the human threshold isn’t always a blessing. As the horses began to buck, and kick, and whinny in their stables, my ears overloaded, and I stumbled backward . . . backward into peaceful silence. Just as fast as the horses’ tirade had begun, it ended.

“Whoa,” Albert said.

“Vampires spook horses. Bad,” Bubba said as he emerged from the

stables. “You blood suckers are some of the ultimate predators, and a horse’s senses are finely tuned to that sorta thing. Hell, even I get goose bumps when I stand too close to you.”

“So, I can’t ride one?” I asked, still trying to get my mental feet back under me.

“You won’t even be able to stay in the same room as one. The minute you’re there, every nerve and sense that poor horse has will go haywire. Since you’re strong, you’ll probably be able to subdue one and climb on top of it, but riding it with any real control? You can forget that shit right here, right now.”

“Bastards.” Albert said.

“Maybe, but this might work to my advantage,” I said. “I mean, their guy will be riding a horse, too. Won’t me being there spook his horse as well? At least I can put us on an even playing field.”

“Yeah! Good thinking.” Albert was clearly on board, but Bubba was already shaking his head no.

“Dragon magic,” he said simply. “They have control over their possessions, including their horses. You being there will surely spook their guy’s horse, but it won’t matter. He’ll just override its fear. I told you already; the damn dracolings think of everything. You have to come out of left field.”

“Well . . . what about you?” Albert said. “Can you turn at will, or are you only a full-moon shifter?”

I briefly wondered why I hadn’t hit on that idea, but seconds later I became quite glad that Albert had beaten me to it. In motion that was shockingly fast given his height and bulk, Bubba had snapped Albert off the ground by the neck and held him several feet in the air.

“Now, I know,” Bubba growled, “that you *are not* suggesting Fred ride me. I am positive you would not insult me and my kind so blatantly as to suggest I submit myself to bearin’ a rider to control me. I’m right, aren’t I?”

Albert nodded as vigorously as he could with his neck being held in a hand the size of a ham, and Bubba dropped him to the ground. In truth, there was little Bubba could have done to hurt or injure Albert. Raised zombies are

a ridiculously hardy lot, but Albert hadn't been dead all that long, and he still hadn't gotten used to things like not fearing death. He and I were similar in that regard. The difference was that I was ever so slowly learning to pick my battles.

"He's right, you know," I said. "If you can turn at will, then you're probably the only chance we really have."

Bubba turned on me, and for a second I thought he was going to throttle me by the neck, too. His eyes were big, and there was a vein bulging in his neck. Knowing I was stronger than him didn't do much to cut the fear of having a giant man stare at me that way, so I finished my proposal with extra haste.

"It's the only chance Krystal has, too."

It was like I'd stuck a pin in a balloon. Bubba's sudden ferocity slipped away like mercury running off a table, leaving me looking at a large, proud, powerful man who suddenly seemed very tired and unsure.

"I can turn at will, but it's one of the highest dishonors for a weresteed to be ridden like a common horse," Bubba protested weakly.

"Don't think of me as a rider," I said. "Think of me as a partner. Or think of me as a friend you're doing a favor for. I don't really care what titles we put on it, as long as it gives us a fighting chance of winning our freedom back."

"You know, pride aside, it seems like the dracolings would have remembered that Bubba was a weresteed," Albert said. "That makes the whole horse thing just a small pain in the ass instead of a deal breaker. I mean, they even gave him his freedom on casino grounds so he could work with us. Weird."

I blinked in surprise. He was right. They had to know that Bubba would consent to being ridden if it meant saving Krystal and himself. Which meant there was something we were still missing.

"Actually, I think I can guess why they didn't count me as an option," Bubba said with a sigh. "I told you I was in a different situation than most weresteeds. Well . . . you know what? Just watch."

As I kept my eyes trained on him, Bubba seemed to ripple, like a pond that a stone had just been chunked into. His skin became darker, and his hands grew hard as his fingers merged together. His eyes became huge as his face elongated. His body began to shift, and a small popping sound registered to my ears as his clothes unsnapped. It seemed everything he wore was designed to snap off without tearing when he turned. I suppose that would be something of a must for a shape shifter on a budget.

It sounds as though it took some time, but that is only through my own amped up perception. In truth, only seconds passed between Bubba telling us to watch and Albert and I gazing upon a beautiful black-haired steed. It seemed strong and powerful, the kind of horse that made other horses slink back to their stables and munch on an oat bag rather than occupy the same track as such a beast. There was really only one problem.

“You’re a pony!” Albert shrieked in odd delight. He was right through. Massive as Bubba was in human form, he was somewhat less imposing while hooved. He came up to maybe my waist, and my figure was not one of height and intimidation. Albert raced over and began stroking Bubba the horse’s head. There was a sound like a rubber band snapping, and Bubba was back in his normal form, immediately gathering up his clothes.

“So,” I said to gently broach the subject once Bubba’s pants were back on.

“He’s right,” Bubba said curtly. “I’m a pony. I’m thirteen hands high, which makes me a big damn pony, but still a hand short of being a horse. Joust horses are supposed to be the biggest of the breed, so they can bring more power and height for their rider. If we use me, then we’ve as good as lost.”

“Maybe,” I said. “But then again, I’m not anyone’s ideal jousting. I took this bet because I’m really good at chess, which is ultimately the same thing as saying I’m bad at everything physical.”

“So, we’re double fucked?” Bubba asked.

“Probably,” I admitted. “We have to try, though. I mean, I hate sports, and competition makes me a little nauseous, and the idea of physically

engaging with someone turns my legs to jelly. But what other choice do we have?”

“We’ll get our asses kicked,” Bubba said.

“I’ve gotten my ass kicked a whole lot of times. One more probably won’t kill me. Besides, at least with a steed who won’t buck me, we have a shot at getting lucky.”

Bubba chuckled. “A vampire riding a pony. It certainly does come out of left field.”

“So what now?”

“Now, we practice. We’ve only got a few hours before we’re all slaves for life.”

## 7.

“How’s it looking out there?” I asked as Albert came scurrying back into our stable. We’d discovered that the stables on the opposite of the arena were empty of horses and used for equipment, so we’d set up shop there to get gear for the match. We’d spent several hours riding and getting comfortable with the lance and made some key discoveries. Bubba’s height really was a detriment, my aim was one as well, and it was damn hard to find a saddle that would fit a pony in a stable stocked for jousting horses.

“Pretty full,” Albert said. People had been filtering in for nearly an hour, and sooner or later, we’d be called out into the arena. Some casino workers had given us the rundown a few hours previously. Apparently, we would be called onto the floor and make introductions. Then Morgan would explain the rules, and we would bow to one another, and the fight would start. I guess I wasn’t surprised a shrewd businessman like Morgan was filling the seats for this show; I just hoped that didn’t mean I was in deep shit if I did something supernatural. If only Krystal were here, I could have asked her who was responsible for secrecy in this situation.

I felt a pang in my stomach when I thought about Krystal. It seemed like every time I’d wound up in this scenario before, she’d rushed in and saved me somehow. A part of me had kept expecting her to come into the arena last night and explain how she’d worked everything out, and we could go home. Sitting there, wearing rusty armor and holding a large wooden lance, it finally sank in all the way. Krystal wasn’t coming to our rescue this time. Today, the only cavalry we had was a werepony, a bumbling zombie, and a chickenshit vampire. I wondered if it was too late to place a bet on the other guy to win.

“You got a good grip on your lance?” Albert asked.

“Huh?” I said, yanking myself out of my reverie. “Oh, yeah, it feels just like holding a baseball bat.”

“When did you ever play baseball?”

“I tried for the team in high school. Didn’t do so well,” I said, purposely

keeping my answer brief. No need to go into details about accidentally whacking the coach in the balls when the bat slipped out of my hands.

“Fred,” Albert said. “Do your best.”

“I’ll give it my all, however much that’s worth.”

“Contestants, please report to the arena!” A loud voice thundered through our stable, indicating it was time for the match to begin. Albert hustled over to the doors and worked them open. They were a touch rusty, so it took a few moments before they were wide enough for Bubba and I to exit through. As a result, the dracoling champion was already out in the arena, garnering cheers and roses from the fans. He was a strapping young man, long blond hair and large physique under his glistening armor. There was no way he was stronger than me, but from the way he moved across the arena on his horse, it was clear I could have ridden for ten years and not had the same equestrian ability he possessed. My only hope was that he was worse with a lance than he was on horseback, and that was admittedly a very dim hope.

Bubba whinnied, and began moving forward, pulling us out into the sight of the crowd. I’d expected the noise to suddenly stop, like a needle on a record, but instead it grew larger. With laughter. I’ll admit we did look fairly humorous, but as I felt Bubba tense up beneath me, I put my hand on his head to steady him. I turned it delicately to where the throne box was. Sitting in one was Morgan, wearing a lavish tunic and drinking from a jeweled goblet. In the other, wearing a scoop neck dress and an angry scowl, was Krystal. He’d dressed her up like a medieval Barbie just to prove that he could. Bubba stamped the ground once and loosened his muscles, telling me he understood. These people didn’t matter, their laughter wasn’t important, and the only thing we needed to focus on was saving our friend.

“Good morn, my loyal subjects,” Morgan bellowed out to the crowd. “Today we hold a joust, for the hand of my own beautiful Lady Jenkins. Standing to the east, representing your king, please greet Sir Galvin!” The laughter decreased as the cheering was turned up a few notches.

“And to the east, representing himself, I present to you: Fred!”

“I think I got shafted on that introduction,” I muttered to Bubba as the

waves of laughter and pointing increased. I almost wished I had worn a helmet to cover my face and hide my shame, but Bubba had pointed out that it could obscure my vision. Besides, it's not like a lance to face was going to do any damage to my head anyway.

"Now, my dear subjects, this match shall be the first to three points. A broken lance anywhere on the body will count as a single point, and as always, should a rider be knocked to the ground in any way, he has lost the match," Morgan said. "If our jousters will bow to one another." I inclined my body as best I could in armor, and Galvin across the arena did the same. "Excellent, now take your positions."

Bubba trudged over to the railing that ran through the center of the arena. We took our place on the right side and waited as Galvin did the same. It took him longer despite his superior skill, since he insisted on walking sideways and blowing kisses to the ladies in the audience. I noticed he threw several extra air smooches at Krystal and tightened my grip.

A small man dressed in period clothes came to the center of the railing and checked to see that we were both in position. He took a few steps back, and then with a jerking motion waved his flag telling us to charge.

I wish I could tell you it was over in a flash and I don't remember what happened, but thanks to the damn vampire sense, I saw the whole thing clearly. Bubba was off like a shot, his size not diminishing the considerable power that being a werecreature afforded him. Galvin was moving quickly too, though, his horse's size and power nearly broaching the speed gap. As we approached each other, I focused on his chest, visualizing it as one of the rings I had practiced with all night. I steadied my lance and drove it right for his sternum.

In a motion as fluid as running water, Galvin rolled his own lance in a circle, knocking against mine to deflect it and arriving back at the perfect position to skewer me dead center, smashing his lance and nearly driving me off Bubba. The only thing that kept me seated was the ludicrous amount of strength in my legs, strength that had been of no help when he'd used simple physics to remove my leverage and redirect my thrust.



As Bubba slowed down to a trot, I became vaguely aware of the loud cheers coming from the crowd. I righted myself and adjusted my seat as an attendant rushed forward with another lance.

That had been unreal; I'd never even had a chance at striking Calvin. He'd read my movements like a book and reacted to them perfectly, all of which was only made easier by the difference of several feet in height between us. I looked across the arena to see him being handed another lance, smiling freely. For a moment I wondered why he hadn't bothered to put a helmet on, either. Then it hit me, he knew he didn't need one. If I'd had any sense of pride at that moment, it might have been crushed.

Bubba and I pulled into position at the railing, and I took a deep breath to try and steady my nerves. I knew I didn't actually need to breathe, of course, but stimulus response is ingrained deeply in the human mind, even after death. It worked too, and I felt myself become more in control. I knew if I used the few advantages I did have, I'd be able to strike Calvin dead center. The attendant came to the center and waved the flag, and Bubba and I surged forward, bent on destroying our opponent.

A few seconds later, we were trotting up to the other side with a new dent in my armor and another unbroken lance lying on my side of the arena. It was no good. He was just too well trained at this for me to overcome him with a few physical advantages and a night of practice.

Albert rushed to my side. "Fred! Fred, are you okay?"

"Well, I'm trying to get used to the idea of living and working in Vegas for the rest of my life, but other than that, I'm peachy," I said as I pulled myself up.

"Yeah, you're not doing too good," Albert agreed.

"No, I am not." I looked up into the throne box. Krystal was staring down at me, looking . . . I wasn't sure. I didn't think I had ever seen such a look on her face. It was desperation, sadness, and helplessness all rolled into one and smothered with guilt. She knew we were going to lose. So did Morgan and the audience. Hell, for that matter, even we knew we were going to lose.

"Guess we didn't come far enough out of left field." Albert sighed

resolutely.

I paused for a moment, looking up at Krystal, then at Albert, then Bubba, then working very hard to remember something Morgan had said earlier, word for word. A light clicked on in my head, and I had a plan. Go figure; I was tweaked out and amped up physically thanks to my vampire status, but the thing that might actually save us was my good old steel trap of a memory.

“Get me a lance,” I told Albert. As he hustled off to take the lance from an approaching attendant, I began working on my armor. After messing with the buckles for a few frustrating seconds, I gave up and just tore the armor off. I stretched my limbs, then leaned into Bubba.

“Can you run faster than you have been?” Bubba stamped once, indicating “yes” in the code we’d worked out during our training. “Good,” I told him. “Do that. Run as fast and as hard as you can. Stay straight along the rail no matter what. And try to trust me because I think we’re about to go for broke.”

Bubba stamped his hoof three times which meant, if I was remembering correctly, “Let’s go beat these bitches.” It had been a long night, and we’d had a bit of fun with the code.

Albert came scampering back and handed me my lance. “Where’s your armor?”

“I don’t need it for this one,” I said.

“Okay . . . why not?”

“Because if we keep trying the same thing, we’ll definitely lose, so at least this way we have a one-percent chance of winning.”

“I kind of figured that,” Albert said. “I meant why don’t you need armor for whatever you’re trying?”

“Just watch,” I said with a sigh. Bubba moved slowly into our starting position, and I checked my legs in the saddle to make sure they were just where I wanted them. Galvin hesitated to take his spot though, staring across at me as I sat sans armor on the back of my pony. He reached up to the tip of his lance and broke off a chunk of the wooden tip. Then he smiled at me and began riding to his starting position. The meaning wasn’t lost on me. Right

now he was essentially holding a giant wooden stake, and if he hit me this time, I'd be nothing but a pile of dust on the floor.

I tried very, very, very hard to keep the sudden rush of fear that hit me from showing on my face. I hadn't expected him to raise the stakes (no pun intended), and in truth, if I'd known Galvin would do that, I likely would have just taken the final blow and lost the match. That option wasn't on the table though, so all I could do was take another stabilizing breath and pray.

The starter attendant jerked his flag, and we were off.

My first thought was that Bubba really hadn't lied about holding back. That black, little pony was thundering down the track like it was a mini-horse of the apocalypse. I was ninety-percent certain that if I'd been able to turn back and look, I would have seen hoof prints in the ground from how hard he was striking it.

Galvin noticed the difference, too, and began spurring his own steed vigorously to match pace. It was all for naught, though. His horse might have had more size, but Bubba was a pissed off weresteed running all out. That meant the only advantages Galvin still had were the height of his horse and his skill with a lance.

As I pulled up my legs and secured my balance, I took away his height advantage the only way I could think of. I stood up on Bubba's back, riding him like several hundred pounds of angry, charging surfboard. It was a precarious position, and if I'd been human, there was no chance I could have pulled it off. But being a vampire isn't all sun allergies and blood dependency. Even with my balance it was a challenge, but it was one I could handle for a short while. With the way Bubba was closing the gap between Galvin and me, I wouldn't need to keep it up for long.

My antics had taken the crowd, and, more importantly, Galvin by surprise. Unfortunately, as we drew nearer, any uncertainty slid off of his face, leaving only focused determination in its place. This man was truly a warrior, and even with the advantage of speed and the leveling of our heights, there was no chance I'd be able to best him in a joust.

Luckily, he didn't know that I was no longer competing in the joust. I'd

moved on to a more modern game.

The two of us drew within lance range, and Galvin waited the split second to deflect my thrust. The thrust never came, though. I kept both hands locked on the lance raised on my right side, but made no movements to aim it at Galvin's body. In a fraction of a second, Galvin read the course of my lance and knew I wasn't aiming for him. I'm not sure if he paused to wonder why, or simply didn't care, but he aimed that giant stake at my heart without hesitation and went for the kill.

My left hand smashed against his lance, leaving my own weapon and protecting my heart by pushing his blow over my shoulder. Disappointment smeared across his handsome face as he realized it would take another run to bring me down, but there was no fear or wonderment. We were too close for me to hit his heart with my lance. As our eyes met in the moments before we were even with one another, he saw the arch my arm was moving in, and comprehension dawned across his face. I was impressed he'd figured it out.

With every ounce of power I could pull from my one arm of undead muscles and the momentum of Bubba's run, I swung my lance like a baseball bat and sent it smashing into Galvin. The force of my blow sent him flying off of his horse several feet away, and it seemed to knock over the horse as well. Unfortunately, it also sent me twirling around, losing my footing and tumbling over. I bounced off Bubba's back and grabbed uselessly for something to hold onto. As I started to lift into the air on the rebound, I wondered if I could make a case that Galvin had fallen first. Before I could fully commit myself to losing, I felt a sharp pain in my shoulder as something grabbed hold and pulled me back onto the pony. Glancing upward, I saw it was Bubba himself who's pulled me down, rearing his head back and chomping into my flesh. I'd never been happier to have someone surprise me with an attack.

The arena greeted me with the dead silence I'd expected when Bubba and I first came out as they decided what to make of the final round. I'd unseated their champion, but in a way they'd never seen nor dreamt of before. At last one man in the top row began clapping, and like a landslide the applause and

cheering began pouring down upon us.

I leaned over to my trusty steed and whispered, “We should both be very thankful I’m no longer physically capable of pissing myself in fear. Otherwise, we would have been doused.”

Bubba stamped once.

## 8.

“You cannot possibly expect that ludicrous spectacle to count as a victory!” Morgan hollered as we entered his conference room. “That wasn’t jousting at all. It was a circus act!”

“Should a rider be knocked to the ground in any way he has lost the match,” came a female voice from behind him. “A direct quotation from the rules you set down, Lord Ackers. Fred was still on top of his horse, while Galvin was gasping on the ground. Fred won, or does this conversation not serve as adequate proof?” Krystal stepped forward from her place at the rear of the room, still wearing the dress but sporting her old ass-kicking grin as an accessory. “Your magic can’t keep me silent because you don’t own me, or any of us. You bet and you lost.”

She strode over and gave me a large kiss on the cheek. “I have to admit, Freddy, you caught me by surprise.”

“We’ll list gymnastic miracles as things we’re thankful for at lunch today,” I said. “Now can we please get out of here?”

“Yes, get out,” Morgan spat bitterly. “None of you are welcome in my hotel any longer. Your things will be waiting at the front desk.”

“No worries,” Krystal said with a smile. “Lord Vestrin owns the Bellagio, and I think he’ll welcome us with open arms after hearing how we aided in your humiliating loss today.”

Morgan’s face grew white as he clenched his fists with rage. I began to realize that dracolings could handle a lot of things with casual calm, but losing bets and face were certainly not on that list.

“Oh, before we go, though, there is one last piece of business to attend to,” Krystal said, walking back over to Morgan.

“And what is that?” Morgan asked, sneer firmly affixed to his sour face.

Krystal gave him a large grin, then drilled her knee directly into his groin. Morgan let out a guttural gasp and crashed to the ground, his attendants surging forward to help him, and the bodyguards making a beeline for

Krystal. Bubba took two steps forward and cracked his knuckles, while I opened my mouth and allowed my fangs to extend. I was useless in a real fight, but after today they didn't know that. The bodyguards reconsidered just how much they needed this job and backed off as Krystal turned and strode out the door. We followed quickly, pausing only as Krystal turned and tossed a final word to Morgan over her shoulder.

"Next time you tell me to be seen and not heard, I won't just kick them, I'll take them home as my fucking trophies."



"Can I just say how much I love this town for being anti-sunlight?" We were sitting at the table of yet another buffet while Krystal and Bubba plowed their way through a Thanksgiving smorgasbord. The truly shocking part was that Krystal was keeping pace with our gigantic new friend. "I mean, it's noon, and there's not a shred of natural light anywhere in this building. Plus, there are underground lots for us to park in. It's great. I feel great."

"Maybe you feel great because you finally got to put the smack down on someone." Krystal laughed. "My little Freddy is all grown up. This mean you're going to hang up your calculator and turn into a real ass-kicking vampire?"

"I somehow doubt it," I said. "Today was . . . well, let's call it a fluke."

"What do you mean?" Krystal asked. "You were awesome! I know you always say you can't stand physical confrontation, but you floored that douchebag without hesitation."

"I wouldn't say 'without hesitation,'" I protested. "I just used a visualization method to get my mind working in a more proper alignment with what my body needed to do."

"What the hell are you trying to say here?" Bubba asked, looking up from a huge rack of ribs.

"Um . . . at the last moment, I closed my eyes and pretended he was a

baseball,” I admitted.

There was a beat of silence, then horror as everyone realized I was serious. The tension was broken by Krystal’s unrestrained laughter, then Bubba’s, then Albert’s, and finally my own, joining in for no other reason than we were finally safe, and I could laugh without fear.

“You know, I have to admit that does make a lot more sense,” Krystal said as her laughter died down to mere giggles. “I was wondering how Freddy finally found the balls to whack the crap out of someone. Now I know. All the balls were in his head.”

“Don’t sell him too short,” Bubba said. “After all, he went into the final run planning on doing it, even if he had to cheat a bit to pull off the execution.”

“True. Even that’s a big step for Freddy.”

“Never underestimate what a man will do to protect the people he cares about,” Bubba said with just a hair too much intensity.

“I won’t.” Krystal’s voice had a rare tone of sincerity.

“Right . . . well, then I could go for some ice cream,” Bubba said quickly, as he seemed to realize the direction our conversation had taken. “Albert, what do you say we hit the sundae bar?”

“But I don’t need to eat,” Albert half-heartedly protested.

“And I don’t need to drink beer, but that sure as shit ain’t stopped me. Now, come on, zombie boy,” Bubba said, all but picking Albert up and dragging him across the buffet.

“I think someone might have a crush,” I said when Bubba was gone.

“You noticed? I’m surprised. You’re usually not too perceptive with that sort of thing.”

“Well, he’s not doing much to hide it,” I said.

“No, you’re right,” she said. “I hope it doesn’t make you too uncomfortable, though. If you’re okay with it, I’m going to suggest Bubba set up roots in our city for a little while. I think having some friends around might help keep his addiction under control.”

“I guess that makes . . . Wait—what do you mean *our* city?” I asked. “I



live there, but you only come in for business and the like. Isn't your actual apartment somewhere in the Midwest?"

"I wanted to make it a surprise, but I put in a transfer request, and it got accepted," Krystal said with a big grin. "The Agency is already looking for suitable apartments in your area."

"Really?" I said in shock. I knew things had been going well, but I'd never imagined she would go out of her way to be closer to me.

"Really," she assured me. "I'll still be gone a lot, of course. I have to go where the job takes me and all, but this means I don't have to keep making special trips. My default place in the world will be in the same town as you."

"And Albert," I reminded her.

"And your live-in zombie assistant," she said. "And Bubba, if his feelings don't make you feel too awkward."

I stopped to think about it. Yes, I was massively insecure that a girl like Krystal was with me, but her moving closer to me had given my confidence a shot of vigor. Aside from that, I knew what it was like to feel all alone in the world. Since I'd met Krystal, and even Albert, my life had felt far fuller than it ever did when I was alive. Would it really be right of me to deny someone else that experience just because I had low self-esteem?

"Okay," I said, caving. "Tell him to get a place in Winslow. Just see if you can get him to not hit on you blatantly in front of me."

Krystal snorted out a laugh. "Hit on me? Freddy, Bubba is gay. Like really gay. Gayer than a unicorn butt-fucking a rainbow. You're the one he has a little crush on."

"What?"

"Yeah, you showed some real huevos today, and you saw how he stuck up for you a minute ago. I think you may have wooed him with your manly determination," Krystal said, barely suppressing her mirth at my misunderstanding.

"Oh . . . Ohhh," I said. "Well, that makes it easier. Invite him out then."

"You're sure?"

"Positive," I said. "Let's get him away from this town of gambling and

sin.”

“Agreed,” Krystal said with a smile. “I did have another question for you, though. What were you going to do if the challenge had been a chess match?”

“Win, of course,” I told her. “I’m not sure if you remember, but I was quite the chess prodigy in high school.”

Krystal reached over lovingly, then smacked me across my head.

“Ow!” I yelped in reflex. “What was that for?”

“I’m not sure if you remember, Freddy, but I was the only person you never managed to beat at chess all through high school,” Krystal reminded me. “So if I didn’t beat their guy, what shot did you think you had?”

“I . . . might have forgotten that little detail.”

“Thank god you’re good looking,” Krystal said, giving me a half-hearted smile.

“You think so?”

“Nope, but you are my champion today, so shut up and give me a kiss while the boys are distracted with hot fudge.”

All things considered, I’d had much worse Thanksgivings.

# A Mage at the Park

## 1.

““Periodontist,”” I said, carefully placing the tiles in position. “Thirty-six points.”

The larger of my opponents surveyed the board, eyes darting about in the shadow of his ever-present ballcap, carefully examining his options. The man cut an intimidating figure, standing well over 6’6” and sporting a physique that years of loading trucks had honed. Indeed, he would have been quite the adversary on another field of battle, but in this coliseum, muscles counted for nothing. He delved into his own supply of letters and made his play. His large fingers moved with surprising grace as he shuffled the new letters into position.

““Beer,”” said Bubba, leaning back in his chair. “Seven points.”

“Good play!” Albert cheered.

“Go with what you know,” Bubba said, picking up a fresh silver can and cracking it open.

I sighed inwardly and took a sip of my own drink, a glass of freshly decanted pinot noir. It was a bottle that had cost more than my usual range; however, things had been going quite well for my business as of late, so I felt it was a justified splurge. My guests had palates that were lower maintenance than my own. Bubba was drinking beer that came for ten dollars a case, and Albert was gulping down soda. Albert had only been seventeen years old when he died, so his tastes still ran to the adolescent. Of course, he’d only been dead for a few months, thus he hadn’t had much time to mature his beverage preferences anyway. Ah, but I should explain.

Albert died in an unfortunate accident some time ago and was raised as a zombie by his amateur necromancer friend, Neil. Bubba was a new friend we had acquired in Vegas when helping him gain back the freedom he had previously gambled away. The fourth member of our group, a government

agent (and my girlfriend) named Krystal, was out of town for work this week, thus I was conducting my first weekly Scrabble tournament with just the three of us. Which leaves only me to be accounted for in the explanation.

My name, as I hope you know by now, is Fredrick Frankford Fletcher, and I am a vampire, though still not the type that inspired swooning or terror. As I'd learned already, it turned out admittance into the club of ultra-powerful undead beings is much like buying a fantastic new home-theater system. Once the novelty wears off, you find yourself realizing that while the method of presenting it has greatly improved, the content generated is still just as lackluster as it was previously. In the same way that my robust flat screen is still shackled to showing reality TV and poorly-thought-out game shows, being a vampire didn't particularly make me more interesting. If nothing else, it was proving to expand my social circle though, and for that I was grateful.

"Albert, you're up," I said, prodding my assistant to make his move. He leaned across the table and stared at the board, tongue poking out ever so slightly in his fevered, yet cold-as-earth, concentration. Albert was an interesting fellow, easily the most upbeat person I'd ever met, both during my life and in the vampiric-after. Krystal had explained to me once that zombies were locked into the physiological state they'd been in at death, and it seems Albert had been . . . midway through . . . servicing him . . . Well, let us just say he was in an excellent frame of mind.

"Pony," Albert said, placing his tile and sitting into his chair.

Bubba cast a sidelong glance at the youthful undead. He could be a bit touchy about his size; however, nothing in Albert's chipper face betrayed a malicious intent, so Bubba shrugged his massive shoulders and refocused his attention on the beer. My own attention was settling back on the board, a bevy of tactical possibilities unfolding in my mind, when I heard footsteps thumping down the hallway outside my apartment. It took a few seconds for the others to notice. Their hearing was not quite on par with mine.

"Sounds like someone is in a hurry," Bubba noted.

"Indeed," I said. "If not for Krystal's absence, I would find myself fearful that it was a troubled parahuman out looking for—"

“Help!” The cry was followed by an immediate rapping on my recently fortified door. Once upon a time, I had contented myself with the level of security provided by my apartment. However, the past few months had reminded me all too well that there was no such thing as too much precaution.

“Sir,” I called cautiously. “I believe you have the wrong apartment.”

“Albert! Please open up! I need your help!” And suddenly the whiny, pubescent tones of my unrequested visitor slipped comfortably in place among my memories.

“Oh, you must be joking.” I sighed, walking over to the door and undoing the deadbolts before my assistant could beat me to it. I pulled back the heavy door to reveal another youthful face, though this one was aged a wee bit more than Albert’s. It was bespectacled like my own, but leaner, with sandy brown hair that was sopping wet. The slightly freckled face was streaked with what looked like tears, and he was breathing raggedly, scarcely able to gulp the air down fast enough.

“Neil? Are you all right?” I asked.

“I’m fine,” Neil spat out. “I need Krystal, though. I have to talk with her right now.”

“Krystal is out of town,” Bubba tossed in, his large eyes clearly curious about the visitor.

“She left for work,” I said. “We don’t know if she’s in the state, or even the country.”

“No, no, no, no, FUCK!” Neil smashed his small hand against my door. To put it simply, the door won.

“GAH!” I yelped, a bit overtaken by his sudden display of emotion. “What’s wrong? Why do you need Krystal? Are you hurt? Can we help?”

“It’s not me,” Neil said, the tears making a renewed entrance to his pupils. “It’s my mentor. She’s missing, and her place is a wreck. I think someone kidnapped Amy.”

“Ah. Well, then yes, I suppose that would be more a task for Krystal,” I admitted.

A small whimper escaped from deep within Neil’s throat.

“Fred,” Albert said from back at the table, “we should try to help him. He’s my best friend.”

I took a mental tally. Neil had tried to overtake my girlfriend’s mind, murder some innocent (if rather annoying) people, and had magically bound me in place for the better part of a night. But . . . he was Albert’s best friend, and while I hadn’t been blessed with an abundance of experience in the world of friendship prior to my death, I did understand the principles it entailed. Since I considered Albert something of a friend as well as an employee, I had to assume the transitive property was in place here. I cared about Albert, Albert cared about Neil, therefore I cared about Neil as well.

Curses.

“Right, well, at least you should come in and rest for a few minutes,” I said, stepping aside to allow him entrance. “You can tell us what happened, and then we’ll figure out if there is anything we can do.”

In retrospect, that was the first of many mistakes.

## 2.

“Let’s take it from the top,” Bubba said.

Neil nodded and took a sip of his water. He’d been sitting on my couch, chugging glass after glass for around five minutes. He still looked haggard, clothes stained with sweat and messenger bag tossed unceremoniously on the ground. He also looked less goth than last time I’d seen him as well, clothed more in pastels and muted browns with the exception of an onyx collar around his neck. It didn’t go with the rest of his ensemble, but I suppose change doesn’t happen overnight. One could consider me an excellent example of that very point.

“I showed up at her place tonight at six,” Neil said, a hair of shakiness tickling his tone. “I go there every night at that time for tutoring. This time Amy didn’t answer when I banged on the door, though. That’s not so out of the ordinary. Sometimes she gets caught up in her work, so I went around to the back door she leaves open.”

Neil took another gulp of water and swallowed harder than it could have possibly required. “The place was wrecked. Beakers and glasses knocked on the floor, tables overturned, just a general sense of catastrophe. I searched for her through the house, yelling out her name, but I got nothing in response.”

“That sounds really scary.” Albert rested a hand on his friend’s shoulder in silent support.

“It was,” Neil said. “And it got scarier the longer I couldn’t find her. I didn’t know what to do. I can’t exactly call the cops to come snoop around a mage’s home. God only knows what they might set off. Then I remembered the girl that arrested me that night, and how Albert said she hung out in Fred’s apartment a lot of the time. It was the only thing I could think of, so I ran over here as fast as I could.”

“You looked pretty wiped,” I said.

“It was seven miles,” Neil informed me. “And I’ve never been much of an athlete.”

“I feel your pain there,” I said. Living Fred had been far from what one might be inclined to describe as graceful.

“Yeah, normally I’d make a snarky comment about vampires and cardio, but honestly right now I’m just hoping you guys can do something,” Neil said.

“Look, Neil, I’m sorry about your mentor, but Krystal isn’t here,” I said, choosing my words carefully. The kid might have been all kinds of worked up and strung out. However, he was still a necromancer, and I was still a vampire. That’s not the type of dynamic where you go pissing off the guy with magical powers. “She’s the one with the training and experience at this sort of thing. I’m just an accountant.”

“You aren’t just an accountant,” Neil snapped. “You’re a vampire. Your kind is supposed to be crazy powerful. There has to be something you can do.”

“I don’t know. I mean, I guess maybe I could try to get her scent or something. I’ll be honest, though. I played around with that back when I first got turned, and I’m not terribly good at it,” I said. “Isn’t there some sort of tracking magic you could do?”

“Sure I could, if I had access to my powers,” Neil said, his eyes dropping groundward.

“What’s stopping you?” Bubba said.

In response, Neil pointed to the black collar around his neck. “It’s part of my probation. The collar binds my power unless I’m within twenty feet of my mentor, who is outfitted with a matching bracelet that acts as a key. Without Amy around, I’m just a normal human.”

“That sucks,” Albert chipped in, surmising the situation nicely in my opinion.

“Royally,” Bubba chimed in.

“Indeed,” I agreed.

“Yes, it blows goats, but it’s not really the point right now,” Neil said, pulling himself up from the couch. “What matters is that Amy is out there, in danger, and probably terrified.”



“We understand. However, the fact remains that you’re consulting people ill prepared to assist in the job at hand,” I said.

“I get that you guys don’t know any more than me,” Neil said. “But you’ve at least got some abilities. And you’re the only people I can turn to with this. No matter what, I’m leaving here and trying to find Amy. I’ll probably fail alone, though. So, please, I need you to help her.”

I wanted to protest our lack of suitability once more, but something in his words stuck out to me. Neil said he needed us to help her. He was specifically asking for assistance for another person’s well-being. Mere weeks ago he’d been willing to toss aside human lives for the chance at attaining greater power, yet here he was unwavering in the need to save someone that was not himself. Whoever this Amy was, she must be quite the positive influence.

“I might know someone who can help,” Bubba said, his thick drawl stretching out his words.

“Really?” Neil said. His eyes lit up with renewed hope.

“No promises,” Bubba warned. “I can’t guarantee he’ll lend us any sort of a hand. If he does, though, we might have a genuine shot at finding your girl.”

“‘Long shot’ is better than ‘no shot,’” Neil said, scooping up his bag and walking to the door. “Let’s go.”

“We’ll need something that belongs to her, something thick with her scent,” Bubba informed him.

Neil patted his bag. “I thought that might be the case. I brought one of her spell books, a couple of scarves, and her favorite pipe.”

“Then go outside to Fred’s car and wait while we get our stuff,” Bubba said. “Albert, you go keep him company.”

“Aye, aye,” Albert said, bounding over to his friend and exiting the apartment with him.

“What do we need to get?” I said once the other two had left.

“Mentally prepared, because we might be stepping into a world of shit,” Bubba said, setting down his beer. I could hear from the sloshing that it was only half finished, yet Bubba was abandoning it, his drinking clearly done.

That, more than his tone, told me just how serious he was.

“Oh, dear. I take it you’re on less-than-stellar terms with this acquaintance?”

“It’s not that. It’s just that we’re about to walk into the home of some serious heavy hitters among the parahuman world,” Bubba said. “I’m hoping everything turns up roses. That said, if things start going south, you should be aware that we’re in real trouble.”

“You know, I think the three of you can handle this,” I said hastily. “I don’t see that I’ll be able to contribute much at all.”

Bubba laughed and slugged my shoulder. If not for my considerable undead augmentations, it would have doubtlessly sent me sprawling across the floor.

“That’s the way to stay calm. Just keep joking,” Bubba said.

“I’m not so much joking as you might hope. I’m pretty awful at this type of dangerous-situation, life-on-the-line sort of stuff.”

“Nah,” Bubba said, waving me off. “I thought that at first too, but after Vegas I know you’re a guy who comes through in the clutch. Just keep a level head, and we’ll walk out of this fine.”

As I was forcibly marched out my door, scarcely giving me time to secure the lock, it occurred to me that perhaps my previous fever of momentary bravery had set an unrealistic standard in my companion’s eyes. That wouldn’t normally be so bad, but given my history of caving to peer pressure and the expectations of others, it could prove to be problematic.

### 3.

“Are you sure we’re in the right place?” I yelled into Bubba’s ear. I was yelling because we were in a nightclub in the posh section of downtown Winslow, with the noise so loud it was nearly impossible to hear anything else. Having enhanced senses has often been a boon to me since my change. As the (and I’m being generous with this term) “music” pulsed with such vigor that it vibrated into my bones, I became keenly aware of the extent to which I missed my crappy mortal hearing.

Rather than imitate my shouting technique, Bubba merely nodded and gestured toward a set of elevators in the back of the building. We traversed the terrain thick with gyrating bodies, slowly inching our way closer to the steel-doored salvation.

As we made our way, it was quite apparent we stood out, and not in a positive way. These people were dressed in designer clothes, buying rounds of shots at a place where the beers cost fifteen dollars. In contrast, Bubba was wearing a flannel shirt and jeans, I was adorned in my usual button down, sweater-vest, and slacks, while Albert and Neil were both rocking an ensemble that would be considered dressed down even in high school. Factor in Bubba’s exceptional height and the youth of the boys, and we should have been drawing a veritable abundance of sideways looks. And yet . . . no one was giving us a second glance. Their disinterest in our absurdity left me feeling all the more uncomfortable.

At last we reached the elevators, only to be immediately stopped by two muscular men in identical black suits. Bubba began what I can only describe as a game of high-stakes charades, trying to communicate to them some concept that I was unable to glean. Fortunately, the doormen were either more skilled or better informed than me because after some furtive gestures of their own, they stepped back. Bubba strode forward, and we followed suit. Once the elevator doors whispered shut, the blaring sound was almost completely silenced.

“Wow,” I said. “That is some kind of sound insulation.”

“Only the top of the line at this place,” Bubba said. He punched the button for the highest floor, and the world jerked briefly as we ascended.

“Is that what all clubs are like?” Albert’s eyes were wide, the sight had clearly left him a bit overwhelmed.

“No,” I said. “Normally the drinks are less expensive and the décor less tasteful. Also generally quieter, though that part can be variable.” In truth, my experiences with clubs listed out at a total of two, though now I supposed I could count it as three. I’d been drug out twice during my time at college, and neither had ended particularly well. Please be aware that I would have happily considered being safely home in my bed as ending well, so that should give you some scope on just how poorly the evenings had turned out.

“I’m more of a bar man myself,” Bubba said. “Get me a nice beer and watch the game, maybe have some conversation. These damn places are too loud. You can’t even hear yourself drink.”

“Which begs the question—why are we here in the first place?” Neil said. “You said you knew someone who would help.”

“I said I knew someone who *could* help. Big difference there. And we’re here because this is where he lives. The club is only the first floor of the building. Higher-up ones are offices for certain persons engaged in often less than legal activities.”

“And we’re going to the top,” I said.

“Yup, because this guy is the worst kind of criminal,” Bubba said.

“Smuggler?” Albert asked.

“Gun-runner?” Neil ventured.

“Assassin?” I guessed.

Bubba shook his head. “Politician.”

We “oooohed” collectively as a group as understanding set in.

“What sort of politician would set up in a building with this reputation?” I wondered aloud.

“One whose mere existence is a matter of national secrecy. We’re here to see the head of the therians in this area.”

“I see. And therians are?”

“Shapeshifters,” Bubba said. “It comes from ‘therianthropy,’ which is the term for everyone who turns into animals. There are way more of us than just wolves.”

“So, this man presides over all of you,” I said.

“Sort of. It’s mostly a position of honor. I had to come make nice with him when I moved to town, sign a few forms, initial a few boxes sayin’ I wouldn’t reveal myself or act like an asshole. I know he also deals with other bureaucratic issues when they come up among therians in town. I guess you could think of him as a weremayor,” Bubba said.

Albert chuckled. “That rhymes.”

Despite the dire situation, I felt a brief, unbidden smile rise to my face. Only Albert could take joy in the sparse rhyming of “were” and “mayor” under such circumstance, but it was impossible not to take joy in Albert.

A loud ding informed us we had arrived at our destination. The doors slid open to reveal a white marble hallway leading forward. Immediately outside were another set of guards, though this set made the other pale in comparison. If the men we’d met when entering the elevator looked as if they could handle trouble, these men looked as though trouble would be sleeping with the light on for a week and double bolting its doors after even a brief encounter with them. They scanned us as we stepped out, assessing our overall threat level, and presumably came to the conclusion that we were acceptable to continue. I had a feeling that process only had one other potential outcome, and it was one I was quite thankful I wasn’t experiencing.

We tread across the plush red carpet, moving slowly forward. There were a set of steps some feet ahead that made it impossible to see what lurked at the end of the hallway. Instead, I contented myself with observing the tapestries hung along the walls. They showed a variety of man/animal hybrids in different historical scenes. One showed a creature I took to be a werebear wearing a Viking helmet and driving back a battalion of human warriors. Another seemed to feature a werewolf donned in armor kneeling before a king, the king’s blade on the werewolf’s shoulder in the process of bestowing

knighthood. The last one before the beginning of the steps almost caused me to stumble, as it featured a wererat dressed in a crisp business suit with the White House in the background. I opened my mouth to ask Bubba about that one, then decided perhaps it was better pursued after our business at hand was dealt with.

We crested the top of the stairs some minutes later, a whole new view meeting our eyes. What stood before us was a large room, the marble floor utterly covered in faux fur rugs. A myriad of people lay on these rugs, some in various states of transformation. They looked on us hungrily as we walked into their line of sight, eyes unwavering from our all too fleshy forms. It was because of their aggression that they drew attention first. That is the only explanation I can give as to why I noticed them before the man sitting in their center.

I've previously described Bubba as one of the largest men I'd ever met, and while that description was apt at the time, seeing this man rendered it invalid. Seven feet tall and certainly several feet wide, this man was the thing NFL scouts' wildest fantasies are made of. His entire humongous body was carved muscle. Golden hair, wild and untamed, fell to his ludicrously broad shoulders. His teeth were just a few shades too white and far, far too many shades too sharp. He rested on a white throne of the same marble the hallway was constructed of. There were no rugs, faux fur or otherwise, softening the seat for him. If it was uncomfortable (which I'm certain it had to have been), he banished any such indicators from his square-jawed face. His bright green eyes moved over us one at a time. When his gaze fell on me, I found myself profoundly grateful I no longer needed to breathe, since hyperventilation was not a possibility. When he finished scrutinizing us he spoke, his voice rough as a law degree and deeper than Plato.

"Bubba Emerson. What brings you, and your guests, to my den tonight?"

"We come seeking aid for a mage who has gone missing," Bubba said, his words concise and his tone subdued.

"A mage? What do I care for the life of a mage? My duty is to the therians of this city. You know that."

Bubba nodded. "I do. However, I had merely hoped that you might be willin' to direct us to a therian with strong tracking skills in hopes of fostering good will. Besides, there are worse people to have owe you a favor than a mage."

The giant of a man sat silent for a few moments, pondering Bubba's appeal.

"No," he said at last. "If the mage has been taken, it is undoubtedly at someone else in our world's behest. I see no benefit in embroiling my people in such a potentially dangerous situation. I wish you the best, but I can provide no aid."

"I understand," Bubba said. "Thank you for hearin' our request." Bubba turned around and motioned for us to do the same. I turned around readily, and Albert did with some reluctance.

Neil was having none of it though.

"You said he would help us," Neil whispered furtively.

"I said he could help us, and I tried hard to make you recognize the difference in the two. We got a 'no.' Now, turn around and leave," Bubba whispered right back.

"No . . . no, this can't be it," Neil said, shaking his head. Before Bubba could react, Neil darted to the side and dashed by him, moving closer to the weremayor. Instantly, there were growls from the rug chorus, matched by tensed muscles ready to pounce. Neil seemed to notice none of this.

"Please! I'm begging you, sir. Please help us. My mentor is a good woman, kind and loving to everyone she meets. She's a great person in addition to a great mage." Neil dropped to his knees and lowered his head. "I'm not asking for much. Just the name of someone who can track her. I'm begging you. Please help Amy."

Bubba pulled the small adolescent up by one hand and firmly clamped the other over his mouth.

"I'm sorry 'bout my guest, sir," Bubba said, haste garbling his words slightly. "He's a whelp and hasn't learned better yet. I assure you I'll instruct him of these lessons myself. We'll leave your den in peace now." Bubba

turned around once more, but this time the weremayor spoke before he could take a step.

“Wait. The boy said the mage was named Amy. Amy Wells?”

Neil nodded from his hoisted position above the ground.

“That changes things,” the giant said. He pointed to a door near the rear of the room. “I will deal with you all in my quarters.”

Bubba swallowed hard, but complied with the order and began walking toward the door. Albert and I followed, though I direly wished the weremayor had chosen a term besides “deal with” to describe our impending interaction.



## 4.

The massive door, also marble, closed with an audible *THUD* behind us. The weremayor switched some mechanism to lock it in place, though for the afterlife of me, I couldn't have told you why he bothered. The thing weighed several hundred pounds, so I'm not sure who could have possibly moved it besides him. Well . . . me, I suppose. Perhaps Bubba, if he were transformed. Albert could probably budge it, too. Zombies were surprisingly strong. And then, of course, if Neil had been in control of his magic, he almost certainly would have been capable. Actually, in light of the fact that everyone in the room could move the door, a locking mechanism made much more sense than I realized in the moment.

"Amy Wells," he growled as he finished locking the door. "I'm very unhappy to hear that something has happened to her."

"With the services of a good tracker, we hope to recover her," Bubba said.

"I cannot merely assign you a tracker," the hulking man said down to us. "This situation is somewhat . . . complicated."

We all stood around quietly, uncertain of what to say next. Generally speaking, I'd learned over and over again not to pry into the life of someone stronger than you. Admittedly, that category had once consisted of a much larger percentage of the population, which might help explain my lackluster social skills; however, the principle was a sound one. The man stared each of us down, as though he were looking deep into our minds, past our souls, where we hid our deepest fears, and he was taking notes.

At last he let out a sigh. His shoulders appeared to sag a bit, and the tension in his neck relaxed. He was still an enormous, imposing man, yet somehow a good portion of the fear he inspired seemed to be diminished.

"Bubba Emerson," he said.

"Yes, Mr. Alderson?"

The weremayor waved him off. "Please, call me Richard. I think you and

I will soon be on far more familiar terms. Bubba Emerson, the things I am about to tell you are not secrets, per se. That said, I do not relish the idea of them being freely discussed. Do you take my meaning?"

"Quite clearly." Bubba nodded.

"And the rest of you?"

"Implicitly," I replied.

"Clear as day," Neil said with more confidence than he possibly could have felt.

"Yup!" The last one was Albert. I have a feeling you already figured that out, though.

"Good, then here is what you need to know," Richard said. "Amy Wells is currently acting as a private tutor to a therian in my town. This therian is very special to me, so I do not take the abduction of her teacher lightly. I take it, in fact, as a personal insult."

Bubba let out a low pitched whistle between his teeth. I didn't know much about therian society, but I could piece together that when a man Richard's size said "personal insult," this dilemma would likely end with someone spending a long time in a hospital contemplating the error of their ways.

"With that as the case, I will be personally assisting you in locating the mage," Richard concluded.

"That's great," Neil said, relief practically dripping out of the kid. "I've got the things you can use to track her right here."

"There is something I must attend to first. It will take some time, but I will be as quick as possible. I trust there are no objections?" Richard said, a tremor of growl slipping back into his voice.

We all nodded emphatically, quite possibly in perfect unison.

Rather than acknowledging us verbally, Richard strode across the room to another set of doors. The room itself was quite impressive, oversized furniture for someone of his mass, lush, ankle-deep carpets, paintings hung across the walls, and a roaring fireplace easily big enough to roast a pig in. When Richard reached the room's edge, he threw open the double doors and

revealed to us another space.

This one was painted pink, with small bits of furniture all over the place. Drawings hung on the wall rather than majestic framed artworks, and the pink, carpeted floor was littered with craft supplies. This room also held two new people in it, a small boy and girl. Upon seeing the doors open, the girl leapt from her position coloring on the floor and dashed toward our host.

“Daddy!” she squealed as Richard scooped her up in one of his massive arms. He set her on his shoulder, where she immediately entwined her hands in his hair to give herself a safe grip. She couldn’t have been more than five or six, with golden locks the same as her father’s, tied off in a pair of pigtails. Her voice was high and squeaky, peppered with levels of enthusiasm attainable only by children and drug addicts.

“You finished early today!”

“Not exactly, Sally,” Richard said. “Daddy still has some work to do tonight.”

“Awwww,” Sally moaned, pulling on his hair. “You always have to work late. You said tonight would be early. You promised.”

“I did not promise.” Richard sighed. “I said I would try my best.”

“Same thing.”

Richard cast us a quick glance and shrugged as if to say “Kids.”

“Sally, Daddy has to do a favor for Miss Amy tonight.” Richard delicately plucked her from the perch on his shoulder. It looked like the endeavor wound up costing him about two five-years-old’s fists full of his hair, but he bore it with nary a grimace.

“Miss Amy is coming? Yaaaaaaay!” Sally began running around in circles, waving her hands like she was certain the secret to flying was just in how hard she flapped.

“No, Sally, Miss Amy needs Daddy’s help with something. That’s why he has to work late. Daddy has to go out to her.”

“Oh.” Sally’s disappointment could not have been more palpable. It’s curious that children can either be expert liars or utterly incapable of hiding their emotions, and the classification changes from minute to minute.

“I guess if it’s for Miss Amy, then it’s okay.” Sally relented after a few moments. “But tomorrow I want to have dinner with Daddy.”

“Daddy will try his best,” Richard said. “Now, if you go wash up, Daddy can tuck you into bed before he goes.”

“Okay!” Sally cried, dashing off into a connected room and slamming the door behind her.

“Sorry.” Richard turned and apologized to us, though precisely what for I had no idea. “She’s at that age.”

There was a derisive snort, and for a moment I was confused. It hadn’t come from one of us, and it hadn’t come from Richard. The girl was out of the room, so who was left? That’s when I once again noticed the other child in the room. He’d been sitting at the same plastic table, quietly coloring during Richard and Sally’s entire exchange. The boy’s skin was so tan it bordered on copper. His hair was an ink black. Noticing him for the second time, I couldn’t shake the feeling that there was something . . . off in the way he moved. Nothing I could pin down, just something different.

“Did you have a comment, Gideon?” Richard asked the young boy whose attention seemed to be fully occupied by the act of coloring.

“Just that I happen to like you people best at ‘that age.’” Gideon didn’t even bother to stop coloring as he responded. I blinked in surprise. His voice didn’t fit with his form. Physically, he couldn’t have been a day over seven, and was likely closer to Sally in age. His voice was strong, though, strong and mature. More than mature—old. “Old” not in the way of denture cream and dinner at four. “Old” in the way of mountains.

“I suppose I can see the appeal,” Richard said, his eyes darting to the door Sally had sealed herself behind. A gentle smile, one I could have never imagined ten minutes ago, crested his chiseled face for a moment.

After that we were blessed with a brief bit of silence until the door flung open and Sally’s voice thundered forth from its interior.

“Daddy! Come read me a story and tuck me in!”

“If you gentlemen will excuse me, we can leave as soon as I’m done,” Richard said, heading toward the door. He paused as he passed the young boy.

“Gideon, these people are my guests. Please treat them as such.”

“Yes, yes, laws of hospitality and etc. Nothing to worry about,” Gideon replied without glancing up from his paper. With that reassurance, Richard went into the other room and shut the door.

The four of us looked at each other at first, no one entirely sure what was going on or what to say about the situation. A few of us threw glances at the boy, Gideon, but it seemed I wasn't the only one who was a little spooked by him. Our eyes dashed over his diminutive form, curious to get a better look, yet terrified of being caught. It was the boy who broke the silence. In retrospect, he might have been the only one who could have.

“So, something happened to Mage Wells,” Gideon said, setting down his crayons and standing from the small chair he'd been resting in. “I find that unfortunate.”

“Did she teach you too?” Albert asked.

Gideon snickered. “Other way around, deadling. Sally is very fond of her, though, and I am always displeased to see Sally sad.”

He began walking toward us, a simple endeavor, yet one that made me feel like I had swallowed a brick. I shook my head and tried to get control. I had never been a particularly brave person; however, fighting the urge to cower in front of a child was a step beyond even my usual levels of conflict aversion.

Bubba and Albert also squirmed uncomfortably next to me. Neil was the only one who seemed to be blissfully unaware of the aura being generated by this dark-haired child.

“A therian, a deadling, a bound mage, and blood eater. Not exactly the rescue party I would put together in this situation,” Gideon said.

“Me either.” The words slipped out from me before the overall feeling of dread could warp or silence them. Gideon smiled at that, and as he came within a few feet of us, he raised his eyes for the first time, gazing into mine. In that moment, I understood why I'd been so uncomfortable since I first noticed him.

The funny thing about becoming a vampire is how little things seemed to

change for me. My weight, sure, and of course all the physical boons were readily apparent. The downsides (silver, sunlight allergies, etc.) were also pretty obvious. The mental aspect, though, that was more subversive. It manifested in realizing that on some primal, subconscious level, I regarded everyone around me as prey. I'd made peace with it early on and rarely spared a thought about the subject since. But I should have because when I looked into Gideon's purple eyes, my brain slammed me with the realization that my mind had been too stupid to comprehend. It wasn't just prey that existed in the world around me.

There were also predators.

## 5.

By the time we got to Amy's office, I'd mostly recovered from my scare, though I was still a bit shaken. Thankfully, the raging impulse to run and hide and pray to whatever god happened to care about accountants had mostly diminished. It was still a bit embarrassing that I cowered in the corner while the rest of the team waited for Richard, but given what he told us when we piled into Bubba's extra-large truck, I felt at least somewhat justified in my primal-brain-powered cowardice.

"A dragon," I said for what was approximately the seventeenth time. "How do we have a dragon in our city? I mean, it seems like someone would have noticed."

"Gideon likes to keep a low profile," Richard explained, fidgeting as he tried to get comfortable. Despite the extended cab on Bubba's truck, the two robust men had little space to move, especially with me, Albert, and Neil crammed in as well. "Dragons have a vast amount of magic. Taking the form of a lesser being is easy for them."

"Can he turn into a dog?" Albert asked, eyes sparkling as untold shape-shifting possibilities danced through his head. Whatever panic mechanism Gideon had triggered in my brain, it clearly wasn't installed in zombies.

"He can turn into almost anything," Richard said. "But he usually stays in that form."

"A child seems like a curious choice for a powerful dragon." Much as Gideon terrified me, I couldn't quite resist the urge to understand more about him.

Something flickered across Richard's face, an emotion between guilt and uncertainty. I wasn't so stupid as to dig further. Whatever he was feeling, it obviously didn't engender a desire to chat, but at that moment, Bubba swerved into a driveway and killed the engine. We had arrived at Amy's abode.

She lived in a reasonably-sized house surrounded by ample foliage.

There was more greenery on her property than in the entire square mile around my apartment. There were other houses nearby, but none too close to hers. We were only a few blocks outside of downtown, so whatever Amy did to pay the bills, she must have been good at it. Lots this size, in this area, were far from cheap.

“Her lab is in back,” Neil said, darting out of the truck and speed walking around the side of the building. Albert kept up with him, though barely. Bubba and Richard took their time extricating themselves from the vehicle. The caution was understandable. With their size and strength, it would be all too easy to bend a door or break a window. Eventually they got free, and we followed Neil to a large wooden door in the back of the house. There were symbols scrawled all over it. They might have been magical; then again, they might have been Japanese, for all I knew. I was about to step through when it occurred to me that a mage might have security features in place more effective than just a dead bolt. None of the others seemed worried about it. Since they walked past and didn’t seem to disintegrate, I followed.

I hadn’t known what a mage’s laboratory would be like, but the one thing I didn’t expect was an actual, well . . . laboratory. Beakers, tubing, microscopes, three computers, a bevy of plants, and shelves of materials greeted me upon entrance. Not literally though. Animated tools—that I actually would have expected. Instead, I got a sterile environment that looked more like it belonged to a botanist than someone who dabbled in the arcane arts. Though the fact that about a quarter of it was wrecked or broken did somewhat dilute the effect.

“Shit,” Richard growled from the other side of the room. He was hunkered into a squat, looking at a pile of broken glass and burned book pages. There were scorch marks on the table next to him, as well as a half-melted, cylindrical beaker. I took a breath in surprise, and a very familiar scent caught my attention. It was one I could have picked out of a thousand, one my brain was unfortunately programmed to prioritize above all other things.

Blood. There was blood on the table. I moved over slowly and took a



closer look. It was smeared across the corner, a solid swipe about three-inches long by two-inches wide.

“Looks like the kid was right,” Richard said. “There was a struggle.”

“The blood is fresh. No more than four hours old.” I spoke before I even realized the objective strangeness of such a statement, but fortunately none of the others were bothered by my blood-assessing abilities.

“Neil arrived at Fred’s place around two hours ago,” Bubba said. “So, whatever happened, it probably happened half an hour before six.”

“Why does it matter what time it happened?” Neil shuffled lightly as he spoke, eyes darting around the room with a frantic energy.

“It matters because Amy is not some powerless human,” Richard snapped. “She is a mage with significant skills and a wealth of experience. There is a small list of things I can think of that can break into a mage’s lab, abduct her, and not leave behind a few pounds of flesh in the process. Knowing it happened at five-thirty tells us it was just after dusk, which expands the list. Whatever took her is powerful, and we’d better hope we figure out what it was before we catch up to them.”

“Oh.” Neil lowered his head and slunk quietly back over to Albert.

“I’ve got her scent,” Richard continued. “Fred, what about you?”

“I think so. What do we do now?”

“We follow it.”

Our group went back to the truck, but when I went to climb in, I felt a massive hand close around my shoulder.

“We’re in the back,” Richard informed me. I hopped into the bed of the truck, then scrambled out a few seconds later when Richard bounded over the side and nearly landed on top of me. The truck dipped down under his weight, losing several inches before rebounding most of the way back up. I climbed back in and found some space near the tailgate while the others entered the front. Bubba turned the keys, and the engine barked harshly to life. Richard pounded once on the roof and pointed south, further down the street we’d traveled to get here. I sniffed experimentally and found that I could still pick out the scent of Amy’s blood in the air.

“Thank you for doing this, by the way,” I said, raising my voice over unmuffled engine sounds and the wind blowing past us. “I didn’t get to say it back at your club.”

“Sally does not have the easiest life. My position makes great demands on my time, and I must leave her alone far more than I would like. Amy is not just a teacher to Sally—she is a friend. She adds a level of familiarity and happiness to my daughter’s life. That is not something I care to see taken away from her. The one who owes thanks is me, for bringing her dilemma to my attention.”

“I think that credit goes to Neil. He’s the one who has been screaming his head off until someone would listen.”

Richard slapped the roof again and yelled “Left!” so loudly that I imagine everyone in the neighborhood suddenly turned that direction in their sleep. He turned back to me as Bubba yanked the wheel and sent us onto a worn, blacktop road. “Yes, her apprentice is very loyal. Not that I’m terribly surprised. Amy has a way with people.”

“Sounds like it.” I drew in some air and confirmed I could still smell her. I probably could have found out where she went by veering around to see when I could and couldn’t smell her, but I had no idea how Richard was able to pin down her direction so effortlessly. It could have been that his sense of smell was that much stronger than mine, or it could have been that he’d practiced his. I had never really been chomping at the bit to expand my vampire repertoire, though since meeting Krystal, my horizons were definitely widening.

“I’ll introduce you, when we recover her,” Richard said. He lapsed into silence save for the occasional thud on the hood and hollered direction. I wondered if Bubba would need the number of a good mechanic to buff out the dents in his roof, then realized Bubba was the kind of person who was perfectly capable of fixing that himself. We were nearing the heart of the suburban community, a large park that was partially obscured by trees. I could make out a winding sidewalk that seemed to wrap around the edge as well as branching off toward the center.

We passed a gazebo situated on a small lake, and it hit me: Amy's smell was stronger here. Much stronger. Evidently, Richard reached the same conclusion because he yelled for Bubba to find a parking spot. The truck lurched around, eventually coming to the park entrance where a small, wooden sign informed visitors it was closed for the day. It was the kind of sign used in neighborhoods full of nice, law-abiding people who have great respect for the rules. It shattered to splinters as Bubba drove over it.

"We could have just moved it," I said to no one in particular.

"Therian Emerson is a good man, but not the most delicate."

"You can say that again." The truck shuddered to a stop and I hopped out, eager to put a little distance between me and Richard when he exited. The others were still in the truck, so I headed forward and tested my nose's abilities. I stepped onto the grass, my loafers immediately growing damp. The scent was less intense than it had been in her laboratory. Probably because by the time she got here, the cut had stopped bleeding. I could still find her scent, but it was duller, muted. The damn thing was everywhere, though. If she wasn't in this park, she had been very recently.

I turned back to relay my findings to the others when I felt something wrap around my leg with incredible speed. There was a rustling sound, a snap of motion, and suddenly I found myself being hauled further away from the parking lot. I flipped over on my back and found my abductor was a long, leafy vine. Breaking it should have been no problem. The issue at hand was that I couldn't bend forward far enough to reach it. Inwardly cursing myself for not sticking to my morning stretches, I clawed uselessly at the ground, tearing out chunks of wet sod, but not visibly slowing down.

When I was able to glance back, I saw the others hadn't noticed my kidnapping yet. I opened my mouth to yell for them; however, that was when the vine stopped pulling me on the ground and lifted me into the air. I twirled about, spinning helplessly as I rose. I was very thankful that vampires couldn't throw up. What I was somewhat less thankful for was that my shifting view treated me to the occasional look at what the vine was connected to.

The creature was twenty-feet tall and resembled a pile of moss with vines and branches sticking out. It had no discernible eyes or face. In fact, the only thing it *did* have aside from foliage was a mouth. Oh, and teeth. A giant mouth with rows and rows of what looked like very sharp teeth. I know this because as I was dangling in its grasp, that mouth was opening wider and wider. With those contextual clues, even Albert could have figured out what was going to happen next in this process. Now was clearly the time for action, so I resolved myself to do what I did best.

“HEEEEEEEELP! SOMEBODY HELP ME!”

## 6.

Fun physiology fact: the human body is wired to respond in a cacophony of terror when it hears certain sounds. This is a leftover of our hunter days, when the people who didn't have such instincts wound up dead. It turns out that some of these responses are wired so deep that not even undeath can purge them. This is why, as scared as I was of the moss monster intent on turning me into an amuse bouche, the tremendous roar of an approaching lion cranked my fear levels up to where I was too frozen to even scream. I thought I was as terrified as I could possibly be . . . Then I saw the beast that had made the noise.

This king of the jungle was massive. It was easily bigger than a horse, and I'm not talking about one Bubba's size. Its huge muscles propelled it forward with astonishing speed. The extra size did nothing to diminish its graceful movements as it leapt from the ground and sank tremendous fangs into the moss monster, or "mosster," as I would later deem it. The creature let out a wheezing moan. Whatever force of the universe had created it evidently forgot to put in a tongue or vocal chords. The mosster turned its attention on the several-hundred pounds of slashing-and-biting lion that was screwing up its dinner plans.

Not one to waste an opportunity to run away, I swung myself upward and snatched at the vine holding me. It took a few tries before I finally got my hand around the leafy appendage. After that the rest was easy. Vampire strength might not let me lift cars, but I will tear up some shrubbery all day long. My landing was far from graceful. Cats might always land on their feet. However, the same cannot be said for accountants. After a quick scramble up from the ground, I checked on the status of my savior.

The lion had carved away large swatches of the mosster's outer layer, exposing a sort of tree-root skeleton beneath. Now, for a real lion, that would have been a challenge. People underestimate how dense a live branch can be. This particular over-sized feline was far from normal, its powerful jaws

turning the skeleton into splinters as fast as it was revealed.

“Fred, you okay?” Bubba had jogged over while my attention was focused on the strange spectacle. Beneath the brim of his faded ballcap I could see a worried expression on his sizable face. “That thing didn’t get a piece of you, did it?”

“No, thankfully the giant lion managed to intervene before I found out if vampires can survive digestion.” We both turned to watch the battle. Even in the strange parahuman world that we occupied, it was still an odd and captivating show.

“Impressive, isn’t he?”

“That’s definitely a word. So, unless Neil or Albert learned some new tricks, I’m guessing that’s Richard?”

Bubba held up a shirt and a pair of pants that had previously been on the weremayor. “Yup.”

“Why is he so big? I know therians usually turn into larger forms of their animals, but . . . my goodness.”

“Like all animals, you get some that are runts and some that are alpha sized. Richard is one of the biggest around. It’s part of why he can stand over the therian community. We tend to respect people who can kick our ass.”

Richard was definitely demonstrating that talent on the mosster. It had been reduced to little more than a flapping mouth and mulch, even its vine tendrils unable to stop the lion’s relentless assault. As he snapped through one of what could probably be called its legs, I noticed the edges of it were melting away. They smeared along the ground in tiny, green rivers, vanishing after getting a few feet from the source.

Neil was the one who answered my evident look of curiosity, he and Albert finally catching up to the rest of us. Zombies can move quickly when they want to. Nerds who ran LARPs were generally less inclined toward cardiovascular exertion, though. Tugging at the collar around his neck and wiping sweat off his brow, Neil panted for a few moments before commenting on the dissolving mosster.

“Magic,” he said, as though that was all the clarification that was

required.

“Augmented construct, actually,” Richard added. He’d shifted back to his human form so rapidly there hadn’t even been time to register it. Bubba coughed with a deep rumble, turned his eyes purposefully toward the ground, and thrust out his hands with Richard’s clothing. The rest of us followed suit, giving the man what privacy we could while he covered himself.

“Amy has taught Sally the basics of such magic. It revolved around creating a mindless servant from the materials at hand. Her lesson merely involved dancing paper figures, though.” It didn’t take long for him to slip back into his pants—it seemed like this was a situation he found himself in with some frequency. He didn’t even bother with the shirt, tucking it into his waistband and leaving his massive torso exposed to the chilly November air. To his credit, Bubba did an excellent job of not staring despite Richard’s objectively impressive physique. The man looked like a living statue from a civilization of oversized warriors. I didn’t play for the same team as Bubba, and I was struck with admiration.

“As much as I like knowing what that was, could someone tell me why it was here? Or better yet, why it decided to eat me?”

“Amy’s scent is strong here. I think we can surmise her abductor is another mage, one who thought to leave traps for anyone who might pursue them. As to its appetite, you were merely the first one to get close. It was fortunate you did. Now we know to be on the lookout.”

“Magical traps and monsters.” I sighed. Not for the first time that night, I wished Krystal was here. Despite being the only human, at least as far as I could tell, in our group, she was the best skilled for this sort of work. Wishing didn’t make things happen, at least not unless genies were real, which actually seemed like something I should check into. But, at any rate, she wasn’t with us, and we still had a kidnapped mentor to find.

“Oh, and thank you for saving me. Almost forgot my manners in the craziness,” I added after a moment.

Richard gave me a sideways glance that I was getting used to seeing from a lot of people. I got the feeling I didn’t mesh too well with other people’s

expectations of vampires. That was fine. I didn't match what I'd expected either. "You are welcome. Amy's trail leads into the woods. Is everyone ready to pursue?"

"Hang on." Bubba shrugged off his denim jacket, removed his faded baseball hat, kicked off his boots, and stuffed them all into a backpack he'd brought along from the truck. He kept his grey T-shirt and worn jeans on. However, it was clear he wanted to be able to shift rapidly if required. I bit my tongue at suggesting he might be more effective in his human form. As I've already said, Bubba could be a little sensitive about his size. Besides, even if he wasn't as big as most weresteeds, he still packed a lot of kick into that little form.

Neil walked over while Bubba was stripping down and picked up a pair of sizable tree limbs that were left over from the monster. Though most of the magical construct had dissolved, and thankfully the mouth was part of that, there was still a pile of grass clippings and branches. Rejoining us, Neil handed one of the limbs to Albert and let the other rest against his shoulder. It seemed everyone was getting ready for a throw down.

We darted into the nearest cluster of trees, Bubba right on Richards (not literal) tail, Albert and I hanging back a bit with Neil. After a hundred yards, it became clear that the mage wouldn't be able to keep up with us on foot, which was fair, given that two of us had supernatural endurance, and two of us didn't have to breathe. So, we paused while Albert allowed his friend to climb into piggy-back position. Our pace increased after that, leaving the first cluster of trees and coming out near the gazebo I'd seen from the road.

Richard turned and began following one of the sidewalks, dashing past the small lake and ducking under a lamppost. I wondered what a human observer would take us for if they saw our strange parade. Drug addicts seemed like a solid bet, stoners chasing some invisible target or running from some imagined beast. I missed the days when I would silently judge seemingly crazy people in a park, instead of being one of them.

We ran up a small hill toward another cluster of trees, but as we crested the top, Richard stopped short. It only took a few steps and a slight shift in



perspective to see what had brought him up short. Bustling about the border of the treeline were squat, semi-human-shaped creatures about three feet in height. Their color was somewhere between an eggshell and a pasty yellow. Squished faces with beady eyes sat atop their muscular bodies. The large caps on their heads made me think they seemed like pale midgets wearing sombreros.

“Heh, heh,” Albert giggled. “Does anyone else think those look like . . . never mind.”

“Dicks,” Bubba said. “Like walking dicks that have been juicing. I guess that means they started off as mushrooms.”

“Regardless of what they started as, I trust we all know where there are going.” Richard said, bringing us back to the task at hand. Bubba started to pull off his shirt, but the weremayor held up a hand and stopped him. “I don’t think there is any need for that. Half-form should be enough for these pests.”

I’d learned at a very troublesome high school reunion that therians could be full human or full animal, but they also had a step in between. It’s weaker than their full animal shape; however, it has the benefit of getting to hang onto things like opposable thumbs and the ability to speak.

Richard’s change was so rapid that even watching him closely, I barely caught all the details. Golden hair sprouted around his neck and across his entire body, which somehow managed to add several inches in height and tens of pounds of muscle. His face flattened into a cat-like nose set just above a large mouth filled with teeth clearly meant for evisceration. Each of his fingernails elongated sharply, tapering off to a point that I had no doubt was sharp enough to cut flesh. Possibly bone.

Bubba’s hybrid form was somewhat less impressive. Though he did grow wider and a touch thicker, he lost about a foot of height, putting him at eye level with the rest of us. His arms were longer than before, a thick, shiny black surface running across the back of his hands along the knuckles. Dark brown fur about an inch long seemed to be growing out of every visible area except for his head, which had darkened to a near black. Facially, he looked like someone had run his face through a funhouse mirror, stretching it up and

down like flesh taffy.

“You three, stay back,” Richard growled, making Neil and me both leap off the ground in terror. Remember what I said about sounds and genetic wiring? He had crossed the vocal threshold. “This will go faster if we don’t have to work around you.”

Bubba snorted, though whether it was in agreement or derision, I had no idea. Richard clearly did, as he bounded down the hill toward his unsuspecting prey, a significantly smaller, but equally hairy, form only a few steps behind him.

For my part, I crouched down into a squat and tried to get comfortable. It was going to be nice to finally see what winning an easy one looked like.

## 7.

“Faster. Faster. FASTER!!!!” Neil yelled, clutching Albert’s back in a death grip while swinging back on occasion to check the progress of our pursuers. I had no such need. My excellent hearing had become a curse, informing me of just how close the giant-mushroom men were. It helped that their enormous feet made a truckload of noise with each step.

It seemed that not all constructs are simply made and then bound to their form. I would later learn that a particularly skilled mage can impart special properties to their creations, properties such as, for example, the ability to grow nine-feet taller and proportionally larger when threatened. Of course, that alone would actually have not been an unassailable hurdle, not for Richard and Bubba anyway. No, what had taken them down was the other aspect these mushmen possessed. A sound like pudding being churned came from behind, and I dearly missed the time in my life several minutes ago when I didn’t know what that meant.

“Incoming!” I risked a glance back as I yelled, trying to calculate which one was firing and where to dodge. Two of them had swollen cheeks and closed mouths, as though they were holding their breath. If only that were the truth. I veered left and saw Albert go right, both of us dodging the thick wads of acid that landed where we had been only seconds before. The goo covered a wide patch of ground, hissing and bubbling as it destroyed all it touched. Even the seemingly invincible Richard had looked pretty horrific after getting doused in it, right before he screamed at us to hightail. From Bubba I knew that, short of silver and beheading, there wasn’t much a therian couldn’t regenerate from. I was far less certain about the effects of acid on undead flesh, and I knew for certain it would dissolve Neil down to bone, hence our escape. In sheer panic, we were run into the very trees that the mushmen had been guarding, since I thought their sudden growth spurt would hinder their pursuit. I’d been right, however not by nearly as much as I needed to be.

The dodge had kept us alive, well, in a manner of speaking. Yet I could

hear more churning pudding from behind me, so we were far from in the clear. There was another issue, as well; the wide splash zone had separated Albert and Neil from me. We were now running at a right angle, growing steadily further apart. I tried to alter my course, but the next volley of acid wads forced me to scramble in a zigzag line to keep from becoming a vampire-accountant puddle. If you're wondering how I was so adept at this, given my usual track record of efficiency, let me just say that while I am not skilled in many things, I am a twentieth-degree black belt in running away.

The mushmen had split up to follow both of us. I had two on my tail, which meant that wherever Albert was, he was running from three. I worked to push that thought out of my mind, not out of lack of concern, but rather because there was nothing I could do aside from trust him. Besides, I still had pressing matters of my own barreling down on me. Vampire speed mixed with an inability to feel fatigue meant that there were very few things I couldn't outrun. However, their enormous size, stride, and similar endurance seemed to register these creatures in that category. The only blessing I had was that they took time between acid blasts, presumably meaning there was some sort of recharging process. I used the grace period to double down on my speed, pushing with all I had to place some distance between us.

The gap between the mushmen and me was widening slowly. I probably didn't have much time left before they could fire again. I leapt over a particularly large fallen log, misjudging its height and barely clearing the top, and landed in a sprint. It was a few steps away when I heard something that was tremendously confusing. Silence. No great crashing feet wrecking their way in pursuit of me. I risked a glance over my shoulder to see something truly surprising, and by this point in the night, that was not an easy bar to reach.

Both mushmen had stopped at the log. They were milling about, looking at me with what I would guess was hate or frustration, though given the inhuman composition of their faces, that is obviously a guess. What was certain was that they'd hit some sort of barrier. Each was careful not to so much as brush against the log, keeping away from it with the same careful

fear I'd shown in avoiding their acid. Eventually they turned back and lumbered slowly away, twisting their heads around occasionally to see if I would leave my area of protection. They were in for quite a disappointment.

Without the focus-narrowing stimulation of eminent destruction, I found my mind wandering about what my next move should be. Bubba and Richard should be safe. With us leading the mushmen away, they could have time to regenerate. Albert might still be getting chased. If the constructs had one area limit, it stood to reason they had more. Perhaps the enchantments that sustained them were bound to a particular region. I was seemingly safe; however, that was likely a temporary status. We still had a kidnapper loose, skilled with magic and fond of setting traps. I couldn't very well go back. I knew the mushmen to be beyond my ability to deal with. At least the next challenge might be something more my speed. Like a turtle, or a three-legged frog.

Walking away from my savior log, I realized that though it had seemed silent with the sudden ceasing of the mushmen's stomping, there was still a sound pricking at my ears. It was a strange combination of hoots, chirps, whistles, and brush rustling. And it was close.

Moving with as much care and silence as I could, I crept through the trees and over the shrubbery. The noise grew louder, and somehow stranger. These weren't just random wilderness noises. There was a pattern to them, one that was somehow familiar and unfamiliar all at once. About a quarter of a mile from the log, the ground sloped down, creating a divot in the forest, like a grassy bowl. Sitting in the center of it was a woman in her mid-thirties, brown hair tied in a series of complicated braids that had come out halfway, and clothed in a flowing dress that had been stained with grass and mud. She sat on a rock, swaying quietly as the various animals and plants around her continued their odd serenade. Her eyes were open, but I had no idea what their natural color was. That was because there was no visible iris or pupil. Instead, a rainbow of shifting colors moved along her eyeball, obscuring whatever lay beneath. It reminded me of looking at an oil sheen in sunlight. I might not know a lot about magic, but even I could deduce the woman to be

under some sort of spell. Even alone that would have been enough, but my nose was giving me additional confirmation as to this woman's identity.

I had found Amy Wells. Now I just had to get her out of here before her kidnapper came back. I leapt into the clearing, the noise growing disproportionately larger despite my small amount of movement. Amy didn't react, so I touched her shoulder gently.

"Miss Wells, my name is Fred. I'm a friend of Neil's, and I'm here to help you."

"Neil . . . yeah." Her voice was distant, ungrounded. No wonder she hadn't had the sense to run away. This guy had cast a doozy of a spell on her.

"That's right—Neil. He got us to come save you. We need to hurry, though. I don't know when your abductor will be back."

"Conductor? I'm the . . . conductor." To illustrate, she raised her hands, and the forest exploded with noise. Only after she lowered them did it return to its strange series of sounds. Okay, that was weird. Weirder still was there was something about the noises that was nagging at me. It was as though I knew it somehow, like a song lyric you are certain you've heard but you still can't recall.

"No, Miss Wells, your *abductor*. The person who took you from your lab. I need to get you out of here." I reached to pick her up, and the small girl placed a hand on my shoulder.

"Buzz off, narc." I can't tell you the next word she said because it was gibberish to me. What I *can* tell you is that I found myself hurled by some unseen force through the air, my head smashing into a tree with enough force to kill me, had I been human. It still rung my bell quite nicely. I had to sit on the ground while my brain swam and tried to recover. In my addled state, the nature sounds somehow seemed to grow more cohesive, and suddenly I was struck by a memory from my college days.

I'd had a roommate in my freshman year at the dorms. Everyone did despite their not being adequate room for one person, let alone two. We hadn't gotten along terribly well. I liked to study, and he would consistently blast music on his side of the room. I didn't particularly enjoy it. Then again,

I've always been a fan of classics and opera, and I didn't understand what the appeal of it was. Until one day, when I'd come home from a particularly grueling exam to find he'd gone to the communal kitchen and whipped up brownies. As I've said before, I used to have a bit of a weight problem, so I accepted his offer without a second thought. That night, sitting in our dorm, I finally saw why he enjoyed this music so much. In fact, I couldn't get enough of it. The memory was buried down under a combination of time and chemical influences, but now that it had surfaced, everything made a bizarre sort of sense.

"This is Pink Floyd," I announced, more to myself than anyone else.

"Shhhhh," Amy said. "We're at the good part."

My cellphone chirped loudly, earning me a dirty look from the girl with the rainbow eyes, and I flipped it open to an unfamiliar number.

"Fred," Bubba's voice came out low and rough. There was a tremor of relief too, as though he'd been fearful I'd be unable to pick up. Clearly, he was under a lot of stress. "Are you okay? Did you guys get away from those things?"

"I did, though I'm not certain about Albert," I said. "Did you two recover?"

"Yeah, took a few minutes, but we're more or less fine now. We found a payphone in the parking lot after our cellphones got melted. Have you run into anymore trouble?"

"Somewhat, though in this case, 'trouble' was our missing mage."

"You found Amy? What about whoever took her?"

"No one took her." I sighed. "We've been wrong the whole time."

"What do you mean?"

"She isn't kidnapped. She's just really, really high."

## 8.

Three hours later, the six of us sat around a table at Taco Bell, watching a woman who couldn't weigh more than a hundred thirty pounds work her way through a small mountain of Cheesey Gordita Crunches. It had taken that long for Amy to come down enough to effectively communicate, and though her eyes were largely back to normal, I still caught the occasional swirl of color along the edges. She'd explained on the way to the fast food eatery, which she had been insistent we go to, about what had happened.

Amy, it seemed, was more than just a talented magic user. She was an accomplished alchemist. She'd been working on a new kind of drug for a very powerful client and had decided to test it on herself. It had worked. Only since the drug had been calibrated for one much stronger than herself, she'd lost all sense of reality and wandered off into the night. The mosster, the mushmen, and the music had all been her doing, though she only remembered the last one clearly. When asked why on earth she would conjure things like that, her response had been a shrug and the words, "I was suuuuuper messed up."

Neil sat next to her, the fact that she'd never been in any real danger clearly not factoring into his sense of relief or hero worship. She was a pretty woman, but she had over a decade on him, and I was pretty certain his crush was a one-sided affair. Still, she'd managed to turn the kid from an aspiring murderer to a devoted and caring apprentice in a few weeks, so who was I to argue with results?

Bubba and Richard were putting a serious dent in some food of their own. Both of them were wearing clothes that were closer to scrap cloth than actual attire, the acid having eaten holes in all the available garments. Red splotches of skin still decorated their bodies, the only remaining sign of the eroded flesh that they'd suffered, and even that was fading away rapidly. Evidently, healing worked up an appetite, though, since they'd each ordered twenty-dollars worth of food, no small feat at this establishment.



Albert and I were in relatively good shape, a few small holes in our clothing where we hadn't noticed acid splash in our hurried escape. I was streaked in dirt thanks to Amy blasting me into a tree, and my sweater vest was shredded beyond repair on its back.

I'd thought we might get refused service due to our rough appearance, but, shockingly, we were not the most wrecked group in the Taco Bell that night. Hell, we barely made third place.

"Ohhh man, is that better," Amy said. Usually these words accompanied the cessation of eating. In her case, they merely came between finishing one taco and unwrapping the next. "Super sorry for all the trouble guys, but I appreciate the ride over."

"I still don't get it," I said, since evidently I was the only one in the dark. "Why would you make something like that in the first place?"

"Fred," Richard said, his tone surprisingly careful for a man of his station. "People of our . . . type are still people. We still have the same desires. We get hungry, we grow tired, we laugh, we love, we hurt. And sometimes, like many other people, there are those among us who yearn the occasional escape from those feelings."

"Even parahumans want to get high," Amy summed up, swirling down some sugary soda in a few rapid straw sips. "Problem is, most of the usual stuff doesn't work on them. You know how much booze it takes for a therian to get drunk?"

I glanced around nervously. Talking in the open about supernatural things was supposed to be strictly taboo. None of the other patrons seemed to be paying attention to us, and since one cluster was debating the viability of robot designs in science fiction worlds while another argued if Lincoln was a time-traveler, I didn't imagine our conversation would stand out too much.

"A lot," Bubba answered before I could guess. "Goes with the regeneration. I can down an entire bottle of moonshine and only get a light buzz that lasts half an hour."

"Right, exactly, and that's just one hurdle for one type of consumer," Amy said cheerfully. "Zees and Vees and all the other UnDees have their own

physical limitations toward tasting sweet release. Through alchemic augmentation, I can create stuff that gets them where they want to go.”

“She is brilliant, the best in her field.” Yeah, that was obviously Neil.

“I guess that makes sense, but it still kind of seems wrong somehow,” I said.

“You drink wine,” Albert pointed out.

“But because I like the bouquet of flavor.”

“Oh. Does that mean you never drank it back before your change?”

Damn. Outfoxed by Albert. If that didn’t prove I was in the wrong, nothing would.

“Right, same thing,” Amy said. “I provide various means for various people of means. I even comply with all the regulations from the ATF.”

“Why do I have a feeling that doesn’t stand for Alcohol, Tobacco, and Firearms?”

“Cause you’re right. Alchemy, Thamataulogy, and Freshness.”

“Freshness?”

“Yeah, I’m not sure that last one wasn’t just out of convenience. The other ATF was founded first, and they figured it would be easier to be covert if they worked under a title regular people already knew. Plus, it saved on stationery and uniforms. It *is* still the government, after all.”

“This is giving me a headache.” I went to set my forehead on the table, then realized exactly where I was and thought better of it.

“I have some stuff back at the lab that can make you forget all about it,” Amy offered. “No charge, as apology for all the trouble.”

“I’ll pass. I’m sorry if I came off as judgmental. I guess I just didn’t expect a mage who was mentoring a kid to have gotten involved in something like that.”

“Other way around,” Amy said, opening the wrapper on her final piece of food. “I got into magic because I got into alchemy. Which I got into because I was into chemistry, which I was learning about because I wanted to get better with botany, which I had taken up studying in an effort to grow some killer weed.”

“She really is a prodigy,” Richard interjected, having finally finished wolfing down (It’s not offensive to use that term. I checked.) a series of Double Decker Tacos. “She got a late start and is still considered more accomplished than mages twice her age. Neil is lucky to have such a teacher.”

“Turns out I’m lucky to have such a dedicated apprentice,” Amy said, ruffling Neil’s hair with the hand that wasn’t cramming food in her face. He still got taco sauce streaked on his forehead, but it could have been actual human feces and he wouldn’t have cared.

“I guess that’s it then,” I said. “Everyone is safe, so we can all go home.”

“Totally with you there. If I don’t whip up a batch of hangover cure, I’m going to be regretting it in the morning. Plus, it sounds like I messed some stuff up while I was tripping.”

“On that note, why were there burn marks, blood, and melted glass along with a destroyed lab?” I asked.

“The drug used a lot of fire magic, and before it was done I had a little accident. As for the rest, I have no idea. Maybe I cast a tornado to cool down. Shouldn’t take too long to fix, but, Richard, will you tell Gideon I need a few more days on his order?”

“He will expect adequate compensation for the delay,” Richard reminded her.

“Of course he will. Fucking dragons. Tell him I’ll add in three extra doses to the order, and to the one after that. If he bitches, you can offer extra on the next one too, no more than that though. A girl’s got to eat.” Amy illustrated this point by polishing off the last of her food. Neil set a bag of Cinnamon Twists in front of her, which she immediately went to work on.

“That should do it. He’ll like the symmetry of the three-by-three offer.”

“I’m sorry, are we talking about the Gideon I met tonight? Looks like he’s around seven years old?”

“You got it,” Amy said. “He’s a pain in the ass about the details, but there are worse clients to have than The King of The West.”

“The what now?”

“King of The West,” Richard said. “He is the highest parahuman

authority in our part of the country, answerable only to The Agency. Various types of our kind will appoint their own regional leaders, people with positions like my own. However, they must all be confirmed by Gideon.”

“Because he’s a dragon?”

“Because he is incredibly powerful, and he is an excellent negotiator. All three dragons that assisted in our rebellion demanded vast lands of territory for their aid.”

“Our rebel . . .” I stopped as my memory flared up. Krystal had told me something about this over Thanksgiving. America was different from other countries because parahumans had been instrumental in its founding, so much so that they were afforded rights and consideration under the laws. Which meant there was only one plausible rebellion Gideon could have helped with where he would have been able to negotiate such power. “You’re saying he was there for the Revolutionary War.”

“Very much so. He led a battalion of warriors in some of the key victories, and he is often fond of telling the story of them over and over,” Richard explained, clearly a little weary of the tales. I could surmise a dragon with insane power and innumerable years of experience could make a tiring houseguest.

“Glad to know I made a fool of myself in front of someone so important,” I joked. I tried to make it sound light hearted, but my nerves shone through.

“No need to worry. Gideon is not offended by people cowering in fear of him,” Richard assured me. “In fact, he prefers it. Reminds him that he’s still got the mojo, even in his current shape.”

“No question he does, though for the life of me, I don’t get why someone with all that clout wants to be a kid, or is crashing with one of his subjects,” I said. The shadow of some deep pain rippled over Richard’s face again, and I decided it was time to move the subject. “I just hope I never give a repeat performance. I’m ready to go home, drink some liquid refreshment, and pass out until the next sunset.”

“I’ll give you a ride,” Bubba said, flashing me a warm grin. He’d been

exceptionally cheerful since we met back up, no doubt relieved to know Amy had been found safely. “Look at it this way—at least you have an interesting story to tell Krystal when she gets back.”

I chuckled despite myself. “That is true. I bet she thinks all I did while she was gone was sit around and play . . . Hey!” I slapped my hand on the table, leaving an accidental dent in its cheap-plastic surface. “I almost forgot.”

“What is it?” Richard asked. The whole table leaned in tensely. After a night of constant surprises, they had immediately shifted back into Ready For Anything Mode.

“We still have a game of Scrabble to finish.”

“Oooh, can I come? I love that game,” Amy said. I was admittedly not overly fond of the woman who had given me a night full of stress and horror, but she had apologized, and it wasn’t like she meant to do any harm. Besides, I had spent most of life with very few people to pal around with. It wasn’t in me to turn away anyone’s advances of friendship.

“Sure,” I told her. “The more, the merrier.”

“Awesome.” She hopped up from the chair and gulped down the last of her drink. “Let me just get some more food to go.”

# A Monster in the Pews

## 1.

It would be lovely to say that the stockings were hung by the chimney with care. However, for all the amenities my apartment provided, a fireplace was sadly not one of them. Instead, we'd used a large wooden stand that I think had started its life as a paint easel before Bubba undertook remodeling it. I have to say, it was a far better piece of craftsmanship than anything I could have managed, though Bubba tended to skimp on the more aesthetic details like paint. And symmetry.

"Hey, Betty Crocker, your cookies are nearly done," Krystal called from the kitchen. No, I don't know why she insisted on telling me this rather than donning an oven mitt and extracting them herself. By this point it hardly surprised me anymore. I pinned the final stocking, our new friend Amy's, to the makeshift mantle, and headed into the kitchen.

"How's the decorating coming?" Krystal asked as I walked in. She sat at the counter polishing off yet another glass of homemade eggnog. At this rate I'd have to put together another batch before the guests even arrived. I had the supplies for it. I was nothing if not a contingency planner, but it was the principle of the thing.

"Slowly," I told her, taking a look at the crisping chocolate cookies for myself. I'll give her this—she'd been right about their level of doneness. "I could use some help."

"Guess you shouldn't have given Albert the day off, then."

"He put in the form three weeks ago. Besides, he and Neil were going Christmas shopping."

"On December 23rd? I see that being real productive."

"I suppose all your gift buying is done?"

Krystal turned away, pretending to be sheepish. We'd been dating long enough for me to know better. That girl rarely had a sense of shame about

anything.

“I might have a few last-minute items to buy. I didn’t expect someone to befriend a damn therian lord and The King of the West, both of whom protocol demands I make seasonal gifts to.”

I was tempted to ask more, but I knew Krystal would just button-up on details. The agency she worked for, just known as The Agency among people of my type, was so secret that most of Washington didn’t know it existed. They made sure all the parahumans in America held to the treaties and adhered to the laws that pertained to them. It was a job that kept her pretty darn busy, so I was glad they’d given her Christmas off. I pulled open the oven and delicately picked up the trays, setting them on the stovetop to cool momentarily before transferring the cookies to wire racks. The heat from the metal trays registered across my naked hands. However, since it wasn’t actual fire, there was no damage or pain.

“These should be perfect by the time the guests arrive,” I said, checking the clock and realizing with a start that I only had thirty minutes left. That would have been plenty of time normally; my friends could be a bit disregarding of social convention, though. There was no telling when they’d start pounding on my reinforced steel door.

“You might need more nog,” Krystal informed me, filling up her now empty glass once more from the punchbowl.

I scowled at her. “There’s a tub of ice cream and a dozen eggs in there. You should have made yourself sick by now. I’ll never understand how you eat so much and stay so lean.” Krystal and I had both been overweight in high school. Add in social anxiety, and you can see how we traveled in similar social circles. My weight loss had come after the change. A liquid diet is quite slimming. As to hers, well, I’d never quite unraveled that mystery. It definitely wasn’t her diet; that much was quite evident.

“Ancient Chinese secret.” She gave me a playful wink that was half-obscured by her blonde hair.

“Says the brown-eyed, white girl.” I sighed. “Can you get the new nog started while I go check the lights on the tree?”

“Weeeell, okay. But only because I want to make sure there’s enough of this stuff.”

I headed back to the living room, momentarily interrupted by the surprise slap to the rear end that Krystal delivered as she moved past me into the kitchen. I shook my head, but there was a smile on my face she couldn’t see. We were a strange couple. I’d be the first to admit that, yet in a curious way, we seemed to balance one another well. I helped her plan a bit more, and she helped me do things more spontaneously than I normally would.

Halfway through adjusting the lights, I heard a deafening crash come from my kitchen. My first instinct was frustration and certainty that Krystal had broken my punch bowl. Then I noticed something strange. Vampire hearing is exceptional, so good that I’ve worked on tuning it out most of the time. As I focused, I realized that there were three other people moving about my apartment . . . and only one of them was breathing.

I’d dashed into the kitchen before rational thought could kick in, which is likely for the best since my rational thoughts all center on the principles of running and hiding. The sight that greeted me was far from pleasant. Though I’d reinforced my door after my first few interactions with other parahumans, I had stupidly left my windows unaltered. After all, I lived on the twelfth floor. Who was going to scale a wall and break in?

The answer, it seemed, was the set of men standing in front of an annihilated window. Both were pale and held themselves with a level of balance I was far too familiar with. One wore jeans, a black v-neck shirt, and tattoos covering several hundred pounds of muscle. The other was lean and dressed impeccably in a designer suit, sans tie. He was the one that immediately drew my focus, chiefly because his hand was wrapped around Krystal’s neck as she dangled several feet off the floor.

“Good evening, Mr. Fletcher,” the one holding Krystal greeted. “Forgive the sudden interruption, but I felt it was high time you and I had a discussion. My name is Quinn Thames, though given the closeness of our relationship, you may call me Quinn. My burly compatriot here is Beauregard.” The muscely man smiled at the mention of his name, confirming my suspicions as



he flashed a pair of long fangs where his incisors should be. A vampire's fangs usually only come out when excited, feeding, or if we will them to. I really hoped those were extended because he felt like showing them off. Neither of those other situations ended well for Krystal and me.

"Close relationship?"

"Certainly. There is no greater bond than between a sire and their child."

The trepidation that had been seeping through me catalyzed into outright fear. I'd never seen the vampire who made me. I'd just been attacked one night coming home from the grocery store. When I awoke there was no note, no guide, no nothing. I'd been changed and cast aside, which Krystal had eventually explained to me meant my sire was a sick son of a bitch. In the vampire world, that was the equivalent of tossing a newborn baby in a dumpster.

"I never met my sire," I said carefully.

"No, unfortunately I was called away on unexpected business after your change," Quinn said, ignoring Krystal's attempts to kick him in the head. "However, I had great faith that you would become an exceptional vampire. All the makings were there. You were repressed, weak, and constantly trod upon. I anticipated I'd return to this city to find you'd nearly drowned it in blood. To say I am disappointed to find out you were coddling around with an Agent does not begin to capture my displeasure." He tightened his grip as he spoke, and I could actually hear Krystal's heart slow down a few beats.

"Let her go. She doesn't have anything to do with this."

"That's where you're wrong. You see, Fredrick, I specialize in this. I can sense a simmering bloodlust from across a country. Someone like you only needed the power to strike back against the world, power I provided. Given your spectacular failure, I must surmise that the element which kept you suppressed is this young woman right here." Thankfully, his grip loosened enough to allow more airflow again. Krystal tried to mouth something to me, but without her voice I couldn't understand her.

"What do you want?"

"Finally to the quick of it, eh? I'll make this simple. I want you to fulfill

your potential. To that effect, I am going to take Agent Jenkins with me. If you want her back, then come to the church at the corner of Eighteenth and Madrigold at midnight. Should you be able to retake her, then she's yours. If you fail to come, I'll kill her. If you come and disappoint me again, then I'll call it quits on this project and kill you both."

"Whatever you want, let's just do this now," I said. There was no way I could take her back. These guys were real vampires, and I was just a guy in a sweater vest. Still, maybe I could give her the chance to escape. Krystal was an Agent, I'd seen her pull off some crazy things before.

I took one step forward and found myself slammed forcefully into the floor. The attack was so hard that it knocked the air out of me. Admittedly, I didn't really need it. Breathing was mostly habit, but it was still an unpleasant experience. Beauregard looked down at me and flashed another toothsome smile. Even as a new vampire, I can move pretty quickly, and I hadn't even seen him close the gap between us, let alone grab me. This was not boding well.

"Midnight," Quinn called to remind me. "And much like yourself, I greatly value punctuality."

Beauregard gave a swift kick to my torso, then vanished. By the time I pulled myself up, they were both gone. The only evidence they'd even been real in the first place was the inwardly obliterated window that was letting in the cold December air. Oh, and the fact that Krystal was now nowhere to be seen. With more effort than I'd have expected, I dragged myself to the refrigerator and threw open the door. Grabbing a packet of blood, I bit through the top and began guzzling it down, not even bothering to get myself a glass first. The minor wounds Beauregard had given me were already almost healed, but the last thing I needed was to be running on empty tonight. This would top me off and finish the recovery.

"Merry Christmas!" My door slammed open to reveal Bubba, dressed in a Santa suit that barely fit him, along with Neil, Albert, and Amy all in tow. They made it three steps inside before they abnormal surroundings registered and their welcoming cheer gave way to sudden concern.

“Guys,” I said, finishing up the last of my blood packet. “We have a problem.”

## 2.

By the time I finished explaining what happened, the last of my injuries had finished repairing themselves. Albert was hugging his legs on the ground, a look of intense worry clear on his face. Given Albert's unnaturally cheerful brain chemistry, that was saying quite a lot. Neil, for his part, was digging through book after book, looking up with cursory glances to indicate he was listening, but continuing his research as I spoke. Bubba and Amy both sat quietly, though midway through my story, Amy pulled out a small flask full of purple liquid and took a quick nip. Other than that, they both listened intently until I reached the part where they'd entered.

"Sounds like the big one had been draining therians," Bubba said as I fell silent. "As for the guy who grabbed Krystal, we should assume he's even more dangerous. Vampires on therian blood can be wild and hard to control. If he outpaced you by that much, then he's had a lot, and that means this Quinn guy is all the more impressive for keeping him as a lackey."

"There's no traces of any psychic interference or magic," Amy said, her eyes glowing the same color as the liquid in her flask as she scanned the room. Sometimes it slipped my mind that Neil's mentor wasn't just the girl who spiked our punch with moonshine. She was also a mage regarded as one of the nation's top alchemists. "Quinn must keep his pet beast on a leash of intimidation, which meshes well with Bubba's hypothesis."

"I hope Krystal is okay," Albert whimpered softly. It was so quiet, in fact, that I'm not sure any of the people with human senses heard it. Bubba and I both did not fall into this category.

"Krystal will be fine," Bubba assured him. "They don't just hand out Agent badges to anyone. That girl could kick a dragon in the teeth if it gave her too much sass." He was doing a good job of sounding sure. However, I was less convinced.

When Krystal and I first reconnected, she'd told me that vampires were big league monsters. It was strange, since I didn't think of myself as more

dangerous than other things I'd seen her curse out without so much as batting an eye, but it seemed obvious these two weren't like me. They were real vampires. The way Beauregard had trounced me exemplified that perfectly.

"Bubba, what did you mean when you said he was draining therians?" I asked as the curious phrasing meshed with my own recollection of Beauregard's physical power.

"Drinking the blood of werecreatures, obviously."

"Oh. Can you smell that in here or something?" I knew from experience that most therians had an adept sense of smell, though my own powerful nostrils weren't picking up anything out of the ordinary. Of course, that didn't mean someone with more experience couldn't notice a subtle cue I'd missed. I got so absorbed in sniffing that it took me a moment to realize everyone save for Albert was staring at me. Even Neil had been drawn out of his rapid page flipping.

"Fred," Amy broached carefully, "Krystal explained to you what makes vampire such dangerous creatures, didn't she?"

"She said we were very powerful. I just assumed she meant the strength, speed, and general difficulty to kill."

Bubba snorted something halfway between a laugh and a grunt of frustration. "That explains a hell of a lot."

"I feel like I'm missing something."

"You're missing a tremendous amount," Neil told me, returning to his books with a shake of his head.

"Be nice," Amy snapped at him. "Not everyone has a teacher to ease them into the parahuman world."

"I'm sorry," Neil mumbled immediately.

"Good." Amy turned to me, pausing only to take a pill from a vitamin bottle and dry swallow it. Given that it was glowing a light blue, I highly doubted that it was actually what had originally come in the container. The purple glow began fading from her eyes as soon her throat gulped the pill down.

"Fred, are you familiar with the variety of classic vampire mythology?"

“You mean how in some movies they can fly, in others they turn into fog, or can shape shift into rats or wolves?”

“Exactly,” Amy said. “Most people think the divergence comes from different cultures taking the myth and adding their own spin on it, incorporating aspects they found particularly frightening into an existing monster template. However, that only makes sense if vampires are fictional, which you now know they are not.”

It was strange dealing with Amy sober. I could almost feel the weight of her intellect as she processed the information and made it more understandable for me. Her eyes flitted about constantly, absorbing observations and taking in every piece of data around her. No wonder the woman spent so much time in altered mental states. This must be exhausting for her.

“The reason vampire mythology is so convoluted about what they can and can’t do is that your kind has an ability unique to their species. Vampires can actually take on characteristics and powers of other supernatural creatures.”

“How do they do that?” Albert asked.

“How else?” Neil said, his tone much kinder than I suspect I would have received. “They drink their blood.”

“They . . . we do?” It took considerable self-control to keep my jaw from hanging open in surprise.

“You can,” Bubba said. “The stronger the person they drink from, the more potent the effects, and the longer it lasts. My kind are their favorite targets, since we give them even greater strength, speed, and senses. If they drink from a powerful enough therian, they even gain the ability to change into their animal for a short while.”

“So, we prey on parahumans just as much as regular humans?” Comprehension was shining like the sun, illuminating the strangeness of my encounters with other parahumans in a blinding light of explanation. “That’s why so many people have been wary around me. That’s why even in the supernatural world I was treated with suspicion. They all thought I wanted

their blood.”

“Not all of us,” Bubba said, jerking me back to reality. “Most vampires are assholes, admittedly, but everyone in this room knows you aren’t like them.”

“This is crazy,” I said, walking over to the couch and sitting down. “You’re telling me that these people who took Krystal could be capable of anything. Shape changing, flight, magic—”

“Not magic.” Amy was quick to correct me. “Only living creatures can access the mana that flows through the world. Drinking the blood of a mage will give them some resistance to magic, especially from the caster they drank from, but no vampire can actually weave magic.”

“Well, that’s something I guess.”

“It doesn’t matter. We can’t let you go in after her anyway,” Bubba said. “It’s obviously a trap.”

“Why trap me? They already had me dead to rights before you got here. Beauregard was so fast he could have gotten my head before I even saw him coming.”

“Wrong kind of trap,” Neil said, partly closing his tome, but marking the spot with his finger as an impromptu bookmark. “The guy already told you—he doesn’t want you dead. He wants you deadly. The goal is to turn you into another pawn like his guy who drinks therians, or maybe make you crazy and unleash you on the city. Either way, I’m sure that whatever is waiting for you at that church is designed to turn you into a monster.”

“I think Quinn already accomplished that a year and a half ago,” I said.

“No he didn’t.” This came from Albert, who managed to uncurl himself and put a reassuring hand on my foot. “Don’t say that kind of thing. You gave me a home and a job when I would have been put back to death without them. You risked your freedom to save Bubba and Krystal in Las Vegas. You even helped us find Neil’s mentor even after he once tried to kill you. You’re a good man who happens to be a vampire. We aren’t human, but that doesn’t make us monsters.”

From the mouths of babes. Or, in this case, zombie assistants.

“Thank you, Albert. That was very kind of you.” He returned my praise with a lopsided smile, then scuttled back to the center of the room. I looked back over to Bubba and Amy. “So, what do we do?”

“We call The Agency,” Bubba said immediately. “I’m not sure what kind of idiot tries to kidnap one of their people, but I know I’ve seen powerful beings turn white as a pale moon at the thought of bringin’ down The Agency’s fury.”

“They haven’t kept the treaties enforced for over two centuries without having a fair bit of power to swing around,” Amy said. “I’ve heard rumors that if things get bad enough, they even have the right to call on Gideon for assistance.”

I swallowed reflexively. Gideon was The King of the West, a full-blooded dragon who was several millennia old. I’d only met him once, and he’d been shifted into the form of a small child. He still scared me so bad I’d gone catatonic.

“There is one flaw in that plan,” Amy continued. “As it stands, an Agency task force might, and I do stress *might*, be able to be rallied in the span of the next hour and make it here in time. While they would doubtlessly bring enough force to take care of two vampires, we must also face the bitter truth that Quinn has shown all the signs of a man who would kill Krystal as soon as he realized we’d decided not to play his game.”

“That’s suicide,” Bubba whispered.

“Undoubtedly. Yet we have to assume anyone willing to kidnap an Agent is already either too delusional to see the danger or so far gone into madness that they no longer care.” Amy touched the side of her head and winced. She reached into one of the countless pockets on her dress and pulled out a small vial that seemed to swirl with green light. A quick motion upended the bottle into her mouth, and a look of tranquility immediately began replacing her pain.

“I agree with Amy,” Neil said. “That’s why I’ve been digging through my books. I knew I’d read a spell for something like this. I just had to find it.” He reopened the book that he’d had partly closed. I realized it was the one I’d



seen him with at the LARP, the inherited tome that taught him his first bit of necromancy.

“The simplest solution is just to make him think he got what he wanted. Let’s make Fred a monster.”

### 3.

**Author's Note:** Since I was not present for the duration of the kidnapping after Krystal was taken from my apartment, she has requested to tell this part of the story in her words, rather than have it relayed.

In a world full of vampires, werewolves, fey, dragons, and all the countless other subvarieties of parahumans we've classified so far, I tend to stand out as an easy target. Bad guys take one look around a room and decide the blonde gal with the nice cans and the lack of any markings of a supernatural heritage is the easiest prey there. Some of these bastards are hundreds of years old, yet they still haven't learned the lesson of not judging a book by its cover. Well, until they meet me, that is. My point is that while I was very inconvenienced by being kidnapped from my boyfriend's apartment, it was hardly my first abductee rodeo.

"Could you put on some music or something?" I was currently chained to an altar in the rear of a formerly abandoned church. Quinn had done a nice job setting the ambiance. Then again, the crazy ones always do have a flair for getting the décor right. All the symbols of Christianity had been wrecked or torn, what looked suspiciously like blood was splattered in key places along the walls, and hanging in the front of the church were the corpses of two sizable men, both clearly supernatural given the spots of fur and animal features interspersed across their bodies. Oh, and there were ghouls scattered about, hissing and snapping as they awaited a command.

Ghouls can be split up into two categories, lesser ghouls and greater ghouls, or Ghoul Lords. The first kind are mindless, ravenous, flesh-devouring machines. They have no sense of who they were in life. All they know is an endless, unabating hunger. Somewhere along the line, people mixed up the mythology of ghouls and zombies. Zombies are like Albert, corpses reanimated for service. It's the ghoul apocalypse people are actually

stockpiling for and writing endless fiction about, though a lesser ghoul won't turn a human with its bite. The only ways to make lesser ghouls are with necromancy or from the bite of a Ghoul Lord.

Those guys are far more dangerous, able to command any lesser ghouls they create and still in possession of their full mental faculties. If not for a vampire's ability to steal powers, Ghoul Lords would likely be near the top of the undead power structure.

Anyway, while the ghouls milling about weren't attacking anything, the sound of their clacking jaws was still annoying as hell, hence my request for music. Plus, I was bored. So sue me.

"Such a brave damsel," Quinn said, perched a few feet away on a decaying pulpit. I'll give him this—the man picked a theme and stuck with it. "There's no need for such demonstrations of bravery. It will not change your fate."

"Uh huh. That's great and all, but I was serious. You guys have obviously been holed up here a while. You've got to have a television or something. I'll take a boombox. The clacking is starting to give me a headache."

Quinn threw back his head and laughed, a rich and elegant tone that had clearly been worked on until it was perfect. Great, this was a motherfucker who actually practiced his evil laugh.

"I do love the bravado you Agents show in the face of certain death," he said, I think intending it as a compliment. "Sadly, we have no such entertainment devices. Our kind is beyond the need for such petty distractions."

"Buddy, there's an all-vampire group in my department that goes and sings karaoke every Wednesday night. They also took three days off when the last Call of Duty game came out. I happen to know for a fact that Freddy still has an active World of Warcraft account and a giant movie collection. Save the Anne Rice shtick for someone who doesn't work with, and freaking date, your kind."

Quinn had me by the throat in less than a second. Whatever he'd been drinking imparted a lot of speed. His face had contorted into a wild snarl,

fangs bared as room-temperature breath swept over me. I could feel the tension in his fingers, the concentrated effort not to crush my throat. He had so much strength it was hard not to, especially because it was obvious how much he would enjoy it. A smart hostage would start playing nice very quickly.

“Well, I know you haven’t been drinking the blood of a mouthwash monster, that’s for damn sure.”

A bulge of the eyes, a tremor of the fingers, and then I was hurled back to the ground. Damn.

“Nice try, but I’m afraid I won’t be giving in that easy,” Quinn said, walking back to his pulpit. “If you were dead when Fred arrived, he might feel compelled to turn tail and flee. I’ve no intention of letting him go that easily.”

“Right, you think you can turn Freddy into a blood-thirsty monster. Someone didn’t get quite enough oxygen to the brain when they changed, did they?”

“Oh, I’ve come to terms with the fact that I misjudged your boyfriend when I turned him. I’d assumed his spineless nature was a result of his physical frailty, and that a bit of power would allow years of anger and repression to take hold. Imagine my surprise when I came back to discover the man I’d turned really was just a fearful, weak-willed coward. So much so that even with the powers of a vampire, he still shrinks back from confrontation and challenge.”

“You’re wrong. Freddy isn’t bold. I’ll give you that, and, yeah, his first instinct is usually to take cover, but he’s also the kind of man who always does his best when the chips are down. I’ve seen him face his fear several times to help when people he barely knew were in need.”

“So I’ve heard. Which is what I’m counting on,” Quinn said. “You see, I know that he is currently trafficking in the company of a necromancer. Once upon a time, that was my specialty as well. Dedicated student that Neil is, I’m sure he’s uncovered the spell of Mortis Invictus by now. It’s a charming little ritual that taps into an undead creature’s true potential. All our powers are

augmented tenfold.”

“Let me guess—it also amplifies your bloodlust proportionally?”

“And our aggression. Though the spell’s description leaves out those choice tidbits, they must be gained through experience. How did you know?”

“Because, otherwise, you wouldn’t be so cheerful about the possibility of a super vampire knocking on your door. Though I’m still not sure how you win if you temporarily turn Fred crazy, and he tears your head off.”

“I’ll be fine. Thank you for the concern. That’s what the ghouls are for. And while the physical effects of *Mortis Invictus* are temporary, opening the door to that side of the mind is something that can never truly be undone. Add in the guilt over his inability to save you, and the rage from when I kill the rest of your friends, assuming he doesn’t gut them himself the minute the spell takes hold, and I suspect dear Fredrick will be a wild beast before New Year.”

“Hoo boy. This night is not going to end well for you.” I should have been more concerned. Quinn was crazy, but the kind of crazy that thought well ahead. Luckily, I knew what he hadn’t noticed. I’d mouthed a message to Fred not to follow me because I would be fine. Coupled with his own natural reticence, there was no way he was going to come try and save the day, so there would be no need to cast some stupid undead steroid spell. Still, it had been a good plan. I’d have to make sure to kill Quinn first when this came to a head. Guys like him usually had escape plans to enact if given half a chance.

“Keep telling yourself that,” he said.

I opened my mouth to pop off another reply, but a familiar sputtering engine cough slammed my jaw shut in surprise. Bubba’s truck was bearing down the street, which meant those damned idiots were going to try and play cavalry despite all basic logic. I was an Agent, for hell’s sake. Did they really think I couldn’t deal with a Bond-villain wannabe who happened to sport fangs?

“Sounds like the fun will be starting soon.” Quinn stationed himself at the pulpit in a somber, expecting pose. We were both tense, waiting for the crunch of brakes and sound of approaching footsteps. In that anticipation, we

were both sorely mistaken.

The front of the truck smashed through the partially-rotted wood doors, crashing through the first two rows of pews and rolling over several ghouls before coming to a stop. The driver's door flew off, and I do mean "flew," as it was thrown effortlessly against the wall by a pair of pale hands. With aching slowness, the creature emerged from the truck's cab, moving like a snake as it danced around a mongoose.

His glasses were gone, revealing a pair of eyes that were throbbing with a dark red light. The normally-fastidiously-fastened collar had been left open, blood staining the fabric along with his mouth, throat, and chest. I really didn't want to think about where all that blood had come from. Strangely, the sweater vest still clung tightly to his torso, adding a surreal element of familiarity to the monster that had formerly been my boyfriend. His fangs were fully extended, and he greeted the room with a hissing snarl.

"Fuck," I whispered. This had just gotten much more complicated.

## 4.

Freddy, or whatever remained of him in the red-eyed monster staring at us from across the church, let out a snarl and smashed his hand through the nearest pew. Splinters went flying, tearing through a few of the nearby ghouls, much to their confusion. Those things would have been on Freddy like drunks on an unguarded bar tap if he'd had a heartbeat, but whatever supernatural hunger drove them didn't crave undead flesh. The working theory was that this instinct was woven into the magic that animated them, since without it, creating ghouls would just become a wild feeding frenzy on one another. They would still attack if they were commanded to, though I still wasn't sure who was pulling their strings. They were definitely under someone's control. That much was obvious. Otherwise, they'd have tried to devour me as soon as they caught a whiff of my scent, and this whole ugly incident would have been over already.

Quinn let out a low whistle. "That necromancer had some serious skill. This is quite a transformation. Pity, I imagine at least some of that blood staining your boyfriend's neck belongs to the would-be magician. Or should I say 'belonged'?"

That line was probably already clichéd in whatever century this dick was turned, yet for some reason, it got under my skin. Probably because I had already had the same thought moments before. Who all had been coming to the party? Nick, Bubba, Albert, and Amy. Amy or Bubba might have been able to fight off Freddy, but if he'd drank from one of them first, then the others were fucked. My stomach turned the longer I stared at the red streaks on Freddy's skin and clothes. Stupid idiot. Why hadn't he just stayed away?

"Hey, Quinn," I called, working hard to keep my more fearful emotions off of my face. The only thing he was allowed to see was my anger, and I had plenty of that to spare. "When this is all over, I'm going to tear your limbs off and leave you with your dick exposed to sunlight. Then I'm going to get a mage that can heal you and repeat the process until I get bored."

He glared at me. I think he imagined I would have started begging for my life by now. I probably didn't fit into his expectations for how this was supposed to work. Welcome to the Krystal Disappointment Club, asshole. Tell my father and ex-fiancé "hi" at the next meeting.

"I've had enough of your mouth," Quinn said at last. "I was going to kill you first, but I think I'll let you live a bit longer while we subdue the man you seem to care so deeply for." He raised his hands, the sleeve on his right arm falling back enough to reveal an ornate bracelet giving off a dark glow. At least that explained the ghouls. Undead couldn't cast magic, but they could use enchanted items, if they knew how. "Ghouls, Beauregard, put our guest in more of a listening mood."

Just like that, the murder switch in the ghouls' brains was clicked on and they began rushing toward Freddy. I noticed the hulking form of Beauregard moving forward as well, but he did so at a much more casual pace. Thankfully, Freddy saw all of this too, though it seemed his sense of priorities was different. Rather than swatting at the ghouls bearing down on him, Freddy did what he'd always done best. He jumped, dodged, and evaded. He ran like hell. The only difference in this and the Freddy I'd known since high school, the one I started to . . . have feelings for, the one I'd been with only hours earlier, was that this Freddy didn't try to get away from danger. He was running, all right, running straight at Quinn.

This, far more than the previous command, seemed to kick Beauregard into high gear. The large vampire clearly hadn't been expecting Freddy to make a beeline for his boss. It took him so long to correct his course that Freddy was able to make it halfway to the pulpit. Then again, Beauregard didn't intercept Freddy so much as crash into him, so the progress was definitely balanced with some setback.

Freddy surprised all of us, though. Instead of just collapsing like he had in his apartment, he flipped over the shoulder cracking into him and landed on his feet on the other side. As soon as his loafers . . . Oh, sweet heaven, he was still wearing those, wasn't he? Anyway, as soon as his loafers touched the ground, he was off again, fangs glinting in the light as he snapped furiously.



Whatever was driving him along, it seemed to be single-mindedly set on Quinn.

Beauregard was surprised by his opponent's gymnastic talents, but that wasn't enough to make him forget what his job was. With more grace than a man his size had any right possessing, he spun around, tried to grab Freddy by the arm. It was unsuccessful, though barely. The magic amping up Freddy was impressive, no doubt about it, but I could see why Quinn was relatively unconcerned. If his lackey had enough skill and power to keep up with Freddy, then the mastermind almost certainly did.

A few more failed swipes, a few more frantic steps forward, and Freddy was nearly in spitting distance of his goal. Unfortunately, that was because Beauregard got tired of pawing at him and took it to the next level. He surged forward, wrapping Freddy in a powerful hug that no amount of nimble movement was going to get out of, then threw the two of them to the ground. They met the concrete with a mighty crunch, and for a moment, the world was silent. Had either of them been living, the sounds of heavy breathing would have filled the air. Instead, there was only smug satisfaction practically echoing from Quinn, the clacking jaws of the pursuing ghouls, and a sullen quiet from the vampire pinned only a few feet away. He'd made it so close, though I had no idea what he'd thought would happen if he—

"NOW!" Freddy yelled, startling everyone in the room with a sentient mind. Well, everyone we'd all known about.

"*Ectorim Novendum, Bicradalio!*" The words were familiar, though not so much that I could place them. The voice, on the other hand, I knew in an instant. Neil's spell echoed through the church, the force in his voice so strong I thought it was going to knock the dust from the rafters. I felt a soft pulse of magic from nearby, again familiar in a way I couldn't quite place. As the words faded, I realized the world had gone silent again, but this time it was different.

This time the world had frozen. The ghouls stood, still as fucked-up wax figures and at least twice as ugly. Quinn was unmoving, which made the look of surprise on his face all the more appropriate. Beauregard was stuck as well,

his head halfway up as he twisted his eyes to find the source of the voice. I followed his eyes to find a small figure climbing out of the back of the truck, chunking an enormous blanket back into the vehicle's depths.

"Neil?"

"Hey, Krystal," he called, giving me a wave. For a young man surrounded by ghouls, he seemed extraordinarily unconcerned.

I noticed one more area of movement, this one far more relevant to my situation. Freddy had peeled off the frozen form of Beauregard and was approaching my spot near the altar. His eyes still glowed with that strange red light, but there was something different in the way he was moving.

"Freddy? You okay in there?"

He reached down and pulled apart my chains with a small grunt of effort.

"No I'm not okay," he said, his voice even and normal despite the strange glowing eyes and crazy-ass antics. "I was halfway here when I realized that in all the chaos I forgot to take the roast out of the oven. It's going to be ruined by the time we get back."

I grabbed that wuss by the shirt collar, pulled him close, and gave him a kiss that would make the dead stand up in their graves.

Sex pun absofuckinglutely intended.

## 5.

**Author's Note: Here, since I was on the scene once more, it only seems appropriate that I resume the duty of recounting the incident.**

When Krystal finally let me go, which I was both happy and sad to have happen, the joy of seeing me not a monster was at last overcome with her need to understand just what the hell was going on. I could hardly blame her for that. It was a trait that likely made her successful in her career. Still, it was nice to, for once, know something she didn't, and I was half-tempted to savor the moment. Then I noticed the sternness in her eyes and remembered that I was not only helping my girlfriend to her feet, but I was also helping an Agent. In this situation, I had no doubt which trumped the other.

"Spill," Krystal said, once she was standing. "What the hell was all that? And why aren't you some crazy, blood-hungry monster?"

"Neil proposed a spell that would have amplified my vampiric abilities by several fold, but we ultimately decided against it. Even though he said it would have made me strong enough to stand against them, I had to raise the point that I would still be . . . well . . . me. I'm not good at conflict, definitely not good enough to overcome two men who seem to relish it, even with a strength boost. He suggested altering the ritual to dull my human sensibilities, but when he and Amy looked it over to see if that was even viable, they realized that a big component of the spell was already mind altering. From there, Amy put together the working theory that Quinn had known I had a necromancer as a friend and was counting on us utilizing the spell to come save you."

Krystal rubbed her ankles where she's been bound, then stood up to her full height. She surveyed the room carefully, checking for threats. There were none she could discern, or at least none I could discern her discerning. Still, she walked over to Quinn and began to test his paralysis, or at least that was what I presumed she was doing by thumping him in the eye.

“So you didn’t use Mortis Invictus. Then what was all of . . .” she paused pestering Quinn to gesture at the wrecked church and the frozen ghouls, “. . . this?”

“Once we knew what they were expecting, it seemed like we might be able to use it to our advantage. Amy cast a spell to give me the scary eyes. A little creative tailoring and some blood from my fridge completed the image of a magically-altered brute.”

“Uh huh, but why?”

I held up my wrist to show her a tiny metal charm. “Amy taught Neil about talismans sometime back. She removed his collar, so he was able to use it to cast that undead freezing spell he used at the LARP from wherever the talisman was located. Evidently, with stronger vampires, you need proximity to be effective. Good thing the ghouls were weak enough to be taken at a distance. We didn’t know they’d be here.”

“That’s great, but what about—”

“All the dodging?” I said, gushing over her question. It was poor etiquette, but I was excited. I’d never really gotten to do the big reveal before. “Amy gave me a potion that enhanced my speed, perception, and dodging. She calls it ‘cat’s dexterity,’ or something like that. Turns out she makes more than just drugs for dragons.”

“Fred,” she said, taking in a long sigh that told me she was trying not to let her frustration get the better of her. I could have told just from her choice of words she was serious. I couldn’t remember the last time she called me something other than “Freddy.” “You aren’t getting it. My question is not how you all managed this little coup—it is why you bothered in the first place.” She turned away from Quinn, evidently satisfied he was truly held. His eyes lingered on her, somehow still managing to convey a sense of fury despite their unmoving status.

“I told you not to come,” she said. “I mouthed it at you when they were pulling me away.”

“I didn’t catch that.”

“Fine, but you still should have known not to bother. I’m an Agent,

damnit, and I know you're still learning what that means, but I'd hoped you'd have figured out by now that it's a title given to people who can take care of themselves. Yes, I have some limitations that let me get captured more easily than others. I've been doing this for a long time, though. I survived just fine without someone riding in to play cowboy and save me from the train tracks."

"I think you sort of mixed genres there. Dudley Do Right did the train-track thing." I knew it wouldn't help un-rile her. I just wasn't sure what else to say. Krystal was the Type B Personality in our relationship. I so rarely saw her serious, even in dangerous situations, that I wasn't used to calming her down.

"It doesn't matter." She thrust a finger in Quinn's face, her exposed flesh mere inches from his mouth. "This is not a threat to me. He is an inconvenience. He is a dinner-plan wrecker. He is an apartment smasher. But that's all. He's an annoyance to me. To the rest of you, he is a very deadly opponent. You should have let me handle my own business."

"I'm sorry. I didn't know. I . . . I just didn't want anything to happen to you."

We were interrupted by sounds from the front of the church. A glance over showed us Amy, Bubba, and Albert had arrived and were trying to extricate Bubba's truck from the pews smashed beneath it. They'd followed at a distance during the front-door-smashing bit. Neil was only along so he could cast his spell, and Amy had only consented to letting her apprentice do that much after laying several protection spells atop him. Between the magic and the armored blanket, an item none of us wanted to ask Bubba why he kept on hand, the amateur necromancer was probably safer than I was during the drive.

"You brought the rest of the crew?"

"They insisted. We care about you, Krystal. None of us was comfortable with sitting around while two vampires did who-knows-what to you. When we first met, you even told me that vampires were only assigned to really powerful agents, and you've never mentioned dealing with one."

"That isn't because they can kill me. It's just because subduing them isn't

my specialty.”

“I didn’t know that. Neither did they. We were worried about you, and no matter how mad you get, I’m afraid none of us is going to tell you we regret what we did tonight because you’re standing here safe and sound. Maybe we were wrong, but we were the sort of wrong that ends with getting our friend back, and I think I speak for everyone when I say we can make peace with that.” Despite my brave words, I took a slight step back and braced tentatively. Krystal was a passionate woman; I was prepared to receive a emotional, if not violent, response.

She let out a long breath and ran her fingers through her hair. After a moment, she walked back over to me and placed her arms around my shoulders. “I know, Freddy. I realize it was well intentioned. This is just a touchy topic for me. I’m a little prone to overreaction.” She leaned in and gave me a kiss, not one like she had when she saw me, but one that still would have taken my breath away if I’d had any. Once she parted, she continued talking.

“I’m serious about this, though. You and the Scooby Doo crew have to rein in any cavalry impulses when my safety is all that’s on the line. Trust that I can handle myself in situations like this, especially against pissants like Qui —”

Later on, I’d be able to reconstruct the memory, noticing what my vampire eyes had seen and distracted brain had missed. The hot spray of her blood splashed across my face as her throat disappeared. It had happened in an instant, a pale hand reaching around from behind her, clutching her too-tan-for-the-season throat, and ripping it out. That would come down the line. In that moment all I felt was the sticky spurt of blood strike my face. All I heard was the moist gurgling of her next words oozing out of her now-exposed throat. All I saw was her fall sideways and flop to the ground, lifeless save only for an occasional twitch.

Once she was gone, I got a great view of Quinn, movements clearly unhindered and right hand coated in blood.

“I told you to stop talking,” he said, eyes on her body as the intermittent

jerking began to slow, “but, like all women, you just didn’t know when to shut up.”

## 6.

Before the last reverberations of his words had finished bouncing off the church's wall, Quinn had closed the meager gap between us and hurled me back several feet. I was able to land on my feet thanks to Amy's potion, but they'd no sooner touched the ground than Quinn was there, delivering a quick blow that knocked me to the ground and shattered the bones in my shoulder.

"Did you think the curse of some apprentice was going to be enough to hold me? I once commanded the magical forces with my own will. The first thing I did upon turning was set up precautions against such manipulations." He reached down and plucked me from the ground, holding me with the hand still caked in Krystal's blood. The smell was nauseating, which was strange in itself. Even if I loved the woman it came from, blood should still smell like blood. If Quinn noticed, he didn't seem to care.

A jerk of his wrist smashed me into the solid, wooden wall behind me. His grip tightened, though it was more symbolic than painful. I wasn't going to be suffocated anytime soon. Under different circumstances, I might have been thankful for that fact. I kicked futilely. He didn't even seem to register the impacts against his torso. Switching tactics, I clawed at the wrist pinning me to the wall, but even my undead nails couldn't so much as scratch his flesh. If Beauregard had been dense, then Quinn was like living dark matter.

"You couldn't even make yourself useful at the end," Quinn lectured. Over his shoulder, I saw a sight that gave me the barest flicker of hope. Bubba had shifted, and now a large pony was barreling down at us, followed some distance behind by Amy, Albert, and Neil. Maybe together, the four of us could—

"Beauregard," Quinn commanded. "Kill the rest of them." As he spoke, a strange symbol flickered across his throat, too complex and too brief for me to make it out clearly. Whatever it was, it evidently gave his words more weight than Neil's spell, since the larger vampire rose at the floor and turned to meet the impending mini-steed. The two collided with a sonorous crash,



and then Bubba was airborne as Beauregard hurled him away with, apparently, little effort.

My struggling grew more frantic. I tried every move I could remember from a life of being bullied and held down. Wriggling, kicking, scratching, even trying to poke him in the eyes. None of it loosened his grip in the slightest.

“No, Fred, no happy escape or quick death for you. It’s clear I made a mistake in turning you . . . I’ll own that failure. But you must be punished for disappointing me. So, before I tear your head from your body and leave it out for daylight to char, you’re going to watch me turn all your precious friends into bloody chunks. Just like I did to your girlfriend.”

If I could have begged, or pleaded, or whimpered, I’ll freely admit that I would have. Sadly, even the undead, or at least my type of undead, need vocal cords to make coherent sound. Instead, I was forced to flounder silently as Beauregard turned his attention to my more vulnerable friends. There was nothing I could do. I was stuck. We were all going to die. And just when life, in a general sense rather than referring to being alive, had stopped being so lonely.

That was when history repeated itself.

One moment I was stuck there, watching death, shaped like a roided-up vampire, draw inevitably closer to my friends. The next, I was falling to the ground. I surprised myself by landing on my feet, then remembered Amy’s potion was still in effect. I had all of a half-second to appreciate the sense of freedom before Quinn’s bloodcurdling screams began crashing against my ears.

He was hollering in pain, the likes of which I hope I die (the permanent kind) long before experiencing. The stump at this shoulder where his right arm had been was leaking blood at a rapid pace, though substantially slower than a living heart would be causing it to spurt out. I cast my eyes about for the missing appendage, finding it with little difficulty. For one thing, it was on fire, turning to ash at an astonishing rate.

For another thing, it was clutched in Krystal’s hands. Well, sort of. Her

hands were now about half-claw, dark twisting things that extended from her middle knuckle and stretched much further than her normal digits. Her skin seemed to be shifting, like something beneath it was rearranging itself. The blonde hair I'd come to know so well turned blood red midway down its length, before ending with a fire red at the tips. That last part isn't creative description; the tips of her hair were literally burning. It was a strange effect, but at least it matched the mini-infernos blazing where her eyes used to be.

"Awww, does the big, bad vampire miss his arm?" Her voice was still partly hers, yet there was another tone coming out in concert with it. The second voice sounded like the screams of a thousand children waking from nightmares, only to find their families slaughtered around them. If I were still capable of bowel movements, I'm certain I would have pissed my pants upon hearing it.

She blurred for a moment. Then she was next to Quinn, her movements so fast not even my eyes could track them. Casually, she held up the flaming remains of his arm. A wide—too wide in fact—smile drew across her face, revealing teeth serrated and sharp, and too many rows deep. There was a slight surge, and the arm crumbled to the ground, nothing more than flakes of ash.

"I told you I would tear off your limbs. Did you think I was bluffing? Did you imagine it was really that easy to kill an Agent?" Krystal ran a claw along his face. Quinn was either too terrified or too much in pain to react. Where it touched, his seemingly invincible skin split open with a faint sizzling and puff of smoke. "You tried to kill me, which means I'm well within my rights to take you apart in any way I see fit. You also tried to kill my friends, which means I'm going to get a tremendous amount of joy from doing just that."

"Krystal? Is that . . . what's going on?"

"Sorry, honey," she said. She didn't move her head, but she might have been looking at me. With the blazes in her sockets, it was hard to track her vision. "I guess I have some explaining to do, but it will have to wait until after."

I didn't need to ask what "after" meant, and I am certain Quinn didn't

either. He was finally getting a grip on himself, marshaling some control over the pain he was gripped by, but that seemed to be getting replaced by a rapidly rising sense of panic. Fortunately, for him, in the chaos we'd all forgotten that he wasn't here all by himself.

Beauregard leapt on Krystal's back from ten feet away, no doubt expecting to send the slender-framed woman sprawling as he had the rest of us. In that regard, he was in for a very unpleasant surprise. Krystal barely twitched at the impact, reaching up and behind her at an angle that should have been impossible for even the most lithe gymnast, and sank her claws into his exposed flesh. She ripped him off and spun around, her free hand running across his torso and shredding his skin like wet toilet paper.

"I appreciate your dedication, but it would have been wiser to learn how to pick your battles when you had the chance. Still, you were just under orders, so I guess there's no need to be cruel about this."

With a single swipe of her hand-claw, Beauregard's head toppled from his shoulder, beginning the burn before it thumped off the dirty carpet. His body was starting to smolder as well, so Krystal released her grip on it and let it tumble away. The lackey finished, she turned her attention back to the true subject of her wrath.

Only it was nowhere to be found. In the ten seconds Beauregard had diverted our attention, Quinn had somehow managed to scramble away. I sniffed the air, thinking perhaps I could pick up the scent of his blood since he was injured. The smell was thick in the air all right, but it didn't extend beyond us. Whatever Quinn had used to vanish, it had somehow covered his tracks very effectively.

"And that's why I hate his type," Krystal mumbled. "They always have escape plans." She turned to me and I put all my effort into not letting out a yelp of terror. "Come on. Let's go check on everyone."

I complied and followed immediately, partially out of genuine concern, partially out of overwhelming fear.

## 7.

Several hours, a long phone call, and many assurances to our friends later, Krystal and I were finally holed up in time to avoid the coming sun. We were at her place, which I had never been to, since mine currently had a broken window and a hole in the brick where it had once resided. For most people, that was an inconvenience, but obviously the sun would do more to me than leave a tan. Thankfully, Bubba had promised he could get it at least quasi-repaired before the next dawn, so I would keep my tenure as a houseguest to a minimum.

Her domicile was surprisingly elegant, smooth marble floors and modern décor along with stainless steel appliances. She'd only been here for a month, so I concluded that everything in here was brand new. I hadn't realized Agents made so much money. Evidently there were a multitude of things I wasn't aware of, though at least one of those was about to change.

I settled into a comfortable chair, glass of a pinot noir in hand, and readied myself. Krystal plopped in an opposing seat and cracked open one of her beers. She was almost completely back to normal, though the tips of her hair were still tinged with crimson. Her eyes, real eyes thankfully, were back to their usual brown, though the bags beneath them spoke to how exhausting her endeavor had been. I strengthened my resolve, this was not a time for pity. Krystal had promised me some answers once we were safe, and now that the night was done and her call with the home office was completed, the time had come to collect.

"So," I probed gently. "You turn into a fire monster."

"Sort of," she said, pausing to take a long sip from her beer. "It's complicated. Are you really sure you want to hear this? You've adjusted well to the parahuman world, but there's still a lot you don't know. Stuff you are probably much happier not knowing. Vampires can be tough bastards, but they are far from the baddest guys on the block."

"I noticed. Look, if you'd asked me last night, I'd have probably

declined. However, after today, I think not knowing is more dangerous than dealing with the knowledge that boogeymen might be under my bed.”

“Don’t be silly. Boogeymen don’t prey on undead,” Krystal said.

“You’re stalling.”

“Yes, I am.” She took another sip of beer, this one much deeper than the first. “Devil.”

“Beg pardon?”

“It’s not a fire monster. It’s a devil. A being of Hell significantly more powerful than mere demons. Most of our more religious Agents believe they were the angels that fell in Lucifer’s rebellion, but we’re never seen defensible evidence of that being the case. The more secular Agents see Hell as a dimension that runs close to ours, and devils as beings at the top of its food chain.”

“Okay, and you’re, what, part devil?”

Krystal snorted. “Heck no, only demons can cross-breed. Devils are too powerful. No, I’m significantly more complicated. Do you remember my mother?”

I nodded. “Nice woman. Sold real estate.”

“She got cancer in my first year of college.”

“I’m so sorry.”

Krystal waved me off. “It was a long time ago. I’m okay. Point is that before I was a sophomore, she was gone. Then, on Christmas break of that year, I got into a car accident. It was bad. I was T-boned against a concrete barrier. Steering column went through my chest and crushed my heart. I died.”

I stayed silent as she spoke, watching her carefully. Krystal was never an overly emotional person, but as she recounted her own death, it was clear she was fighting back a full sobbing breakdown. Strangely, on this account, I could relate.

“I died,” she repeated. “That was when I felt this . . . thing bubble up from inside me. I woke up like you saw me tonight, carved my way out of the car, out of the world I thought I’d known, and out of my nice, normal life.” A

quick motion killed her beer, then she walked over to the fridge for another. I waited until the top was popped before speaking.

“I’m sorry, I still don’t really understand what you are.”

“That’s okay, there’s not many of my kind, so we don’t get a lot of press. Sometimes, very rarely, a devil will break into our plane. When they do, it’s a horrific event, more damage than you can even imagine. Killing them is damn near impossible. It’s only been accomplished twice in known history, and the parahuman-history books go back much farther than the regular ones. There are other ways to deal with them, though. Banishing, if you can swing it. Sometimes they’ll go back on their own if properly bribed. Then there’s the method relevant to our discussion: imprisonment.”

“I have a feeling you aren’t going to tell me you send them to Alcatraz.” I took a gulp of my own wine. It wouldn’t get me drunk, yet the motion reassured me nonetheless.

“There’s a ritual that can be used. Binds them, seals them, holds them. You need a virgin girl and a powerful mage to do it. It . . . well it gets sort of technical here, and I don’t even have the magic chops to really understand it all, but the easiest way to say it is that the devil is sealed in a soul and bound by the blood. The spell is tied to that person’s blood, the circulatory system acting as a constant prayer wheel, every pump of the heart reinforcing the cage.”

“So, wait, you were—”

“No. God no. One of my ancestors, *waaaay* back when. The curse, or duty, or whatever you call it, is passed down along the bloodline. When a woman has a daughter, the onus of the spell begins to transfer. It completes itself when the girl hits puberty. From that point on, if the girl dies, well . . . what you saw tonight happens. The devil that’s bound in me shares my fate. If I die, it will kill him too. So until I bear a child, it will always come out like that to revive me.”

“Why didn’t it help your mother then?”

“She already had me. If I had a daughter, I would lose its protection the minute she hit puberty. Mom never died before having me, so she never knew

about any of this. I don't think any of my recent family did."

"I see. Then it seems like the easiest way out would be to not have children and let your physical clock run out. Surely, it can't revive you when you die of old age."

"You wouldn't believe what it can do," Krystal told me, her eyes darting to the wall, though I sincerely doubt that is what she was seeing. "I won't get old. I won't get sick. I'll be like this until I pass on the curse."

"Wow." Okay, not exactly eloquent, but I'd like to see how you dealt with that sort of revelation. "That is some heavy stuff. I guess your agency filled you in on everything?"

Krystal bobbed her head. "They found me after the wreck, gave me answers and counseling, then eventually offered me a job." Her eyes came back to me and a small smile graced her lips. "I'm not as powerful as most people in my field, though I do get a few perks from my condition. A little bit strong, a little bit fast, metabolism that helped me shed all that high school fat, plus a hefty resistance to certain magics. My ace in the death hole is what qualifies me for this job, and that's the one part that almost makes all of the rest worthwhile."

"I'm glad you found a way to make it into a good thing," I told her. "Honestly, you seem much happier than you ever did when we were both normal."

"Thanks. You too."

I don't even imagine debating her on that point. My life and my unlife couldn't be more different in terms of enjoyability.

"Look, Freddy, maybe we rushed into this thing. There's a reason people in my career tend to date co-workers. Our lives are dangerous by their very nature, and sometimes that danger spills over onto the people near and dear to us."

"Oh please, don't even try to play that card. If you recall, those men broke into my apartment, looking to make my life more problematic. You were collateral damage, and if you hadn't been there, then they almost certainly would have done the same thing using Albert, or Amy, or someone

who doesn't have a get-out-of-death-free card."

"Point taken. They were after you . . . this time. I've had more jumpings and break-ins than you can imagine. Do you know why you've never been to my place before? Because I don't know if it's being watched yet. It will be eventually, and I didn't want you on anyone's radar."

"We aren't worried about that anymore?"

"Not with Quinn the psycho on the loose. He'll blab to anyone who wants to listen. Agents aren't universally reviled, but that doesn't mean we don't have enemies, though. Sooner or later, being with me will mean trouble for you."

"Because I would handle myself so well without your protection."

"I think you'd do better than you realize. We'd line up protection for you, anyway. Sadly, this is far from the first time an Agent has hit this situation."

"I see." I finished off my wine and tried to keep the sweeping sense of sadness off my face. "I have to say, as far as break-up excuses go, this is better than 'it's not you, it's me', but only marginally."

"Wait, I thought you'd want to break-up with me," she said, her eyebrows rising significantly. "I just finished telling you I'm a flesh cage for a devil."

"I'm an undead blood drinker," I pointed out.

"Being with me will put you in danger."

"Tonight tells us that vice versa could also be true."

"Freddy, this life, it isn't for everyone. I know you. I know how you like to live. You think these past two months are as bad as it gets? You've barely gotten past the tip of the iceberg, and the longer we're together, the harder it's going to be to get your peace and quiet back."

I set my wine glass on the table and rose to my feet. Krystal mimicked my motions, I suspect to give me a final embrace before I walked out of the door. Instead, I took her face in my hands and pulled it upward so it faced mine.

"I spent my whole life being very cautious and very safe, and it ended with me very dead under a dumpster. Perhaps I'm not the sort who can overhaul his entire personality with one death. However, I have at least



learned enough to not shy away from something that has made my world, while more dangerous, also impossibly more worth being in.” With that I kissed her, an awkward peck far less gallant than I’d been hoping for. As I admitted, I am not the sort to easily change. Perhaps suaveness will come to me in another hundred years.

“I’ll give you this,” Krystal said once we parted. “You sure impressed me tonight. I get all the magic helping you dodge and making you look scary. How did you pull off the snarling and insanity act, though?”

“If you’ll recall, I’m an ardent fan of cinema and theatre. I even auditioned for our high school’s theatre program.”

“Yeah, then you got so nervous you threw up midway through your monologue,” Krystal added. “I will say, the first half was pretty good at least.”

“Well, there’s your answer.”

“Where’s my answer?”

“In what you said. I vomited every time I tried to act. A physical impulse that vampires don’t have.”

“Wait, so you’re saying the reason you were able to put on that performance is because vampires don’t puke?” Krystal’s already impressive grin collapsed into a din of laughter which grew increasingly hard to interpret as kindly meant the longer it wore on.

“I don’t see what’s so funny.”

“Of course you don’t,” she managed to choke out between guffaws. “Oh, Freddy, honey, you really are one of a kind.” She stifled her laughter long enough to pull me in for her own show of affection, this one far more charismatically executed than my own.

Someday I’d get the moves down. Someday I’d be the cool action star type of guy who could make a moment his own. Someday I would figure all of this stuff out.

Ah well, at least there’s no shortage of time to practice.

# ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Drew Hayes is an aspiring author from Texas who has written several books and found the gumption to publish a few (so far). He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

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THE FANGS OF  
FREELANCE



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About the Author  
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# THE FANGS OF FREELANCE

*Drew Hayes*



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## Preface

I almost certainly do not know you; however, I shall assume you are a lovely person, and it is my loss for not having yet had the opportunity to meet you. Still, I must assume you and I are connected in some way, for the works you are about to read are selections from a journal of my memoirs. I compiled these not in the belief that the stories within are so compelling they must be told, but rather because I found my unexpected life transition to be so shockingly uneventful—at least initially. I place the blame for my aggrandized expectations squarely on contemporary media, filling my head with the belief that a ticket to the supernatural also put one on an express train toward coolness and suave charm.

This is simply not the case. Or, at least, it was not my case. I recorded my journeys in the hopes that, should another being find themselves utterly depressed at the humdrum personality still saddling their supernatural frame, they might find solace in knowing they are not the only one to have felt that way. Given the lengthy lifespan of many of the people with whom I associate, there is no guarantee they will have passed on by the time this is read. Therefore, names have been changed as I deemed necessary.

So, dear reader, whom I suspect is a wonderful person merely in need of a bit of reassurance, take comfort in my tales of uneventful blundering. One's nature is hard to change; sometimes even death is insufficient to accomplish such a task. But be assured that, while you might find yourself still more human than anticipated, you are far from the only one. You will eventually discover that under the movie stereotypes, imposed mystique, and overall inflated expectations, each and every one of us is at least a touch more boring than our images would indicate.

And that is not a bad thing.

—Fredrick Frankford Fletcher

## **An Interview at the Agency**

1.

“Happy birthday!”

We all leapt out from behind couches, chairs, and, in Bubba’s case, an oversized armoire that I’m almost certain was brought in specifically for him to hide behind. Neil let out a high-pitched yelp, dropped the stack of books he’d been carrying, and leapt backward, smacking directly into Albert. Luckily, zombies weren’t pushovers (forgive the literal use of an expression), so he managed to steady the shocked necromancer as Neil fully recovered his bearings.

“Wha—how did you all know?” His voice was shaky, probably from surprise, although embarrassment at the sound he’d just let out wasn’t off the table.

“And just what kind of mentor would I be if I forgot my student’s eighteenth birthday?” Amy made her way over to Neil, shaking her head all the way. It was a small gesture, but notable because small flecks of rainbow-colored light swirled away from her hair. Amy’s usual penchant for testing alchemic products on herself had evidently taken a festive turn for the occasion.

Ah, but if that last statement made no sense to you, then perhaps this is the best moment to pause briefly and explain. My name is Fredrick Frankford Fletcher, and I am an accountant by trade. Also, I’m a vampire. Yes, I probably should have led with that second bit, but to be honest, the accountant part factors far more frequently into my daily life than does my status as an Undead American. Aside from a sunlight allergy, a predominantly liquid diet (bought through appropriate and legal sources, thank you very much), and the power to work for days at a time, being a vampire hadn’t changed me much. It had, however, dramatically impacted my social circle. From Krystal, my girlfriend who worked for a parahuman policing organization known as the Agency, to Neil and Albert, a pair of best friends who also happened to be a necromancer and zombie, respectively, all the way to the very house we were standing in, since Charlotte Manor was a living entity with unique powers all her own. While I’d had very few friends as a human, my parahuman social circle was full to near-bursting, a fact that I was always grateful for.

Charlotte appeared next to me as Amy, Bubba, and Krystal all gathered about Neil and Albert, congratulating Neil on the milestone and Albert on managing not to blow the secret of the surprise party. Although her exact appearance varied with the occasion and her mood, Charlotte was tonight dressed in one of her usual gowns. It looked as if it had been pulled straight out of a Victorian romance, complete with a wide skirt that *had* to use magic to avoid knocking things over.

“Dinner will be ready in ten minutes, Fred,” she reported dutifully. Since most of us rented some form of space or another from Charlotte, be it offices or living quarters, meals were part of the package, not to mention one of her greatest selling features. Even if it was woven together mostly from magic, Charlotte was a fantastic chef, and she’d agreed to put together something special for the evening’s festivities. “I’m going to be a waiter coming around with champagne, beer, and soda in a few minutes as well. Also, Arch and Lillian have both asked me to send you to their respective quarters as soon as possible.”

I’d been wondering where the newest employee of Fletcher Accounting Services was, as Lillian was rarely one to miss a party, or any of Charlotte’s meals. In the months since she’d been freed from her old vampire clan and joined the one I’d hastily founded (The House of Fred, thanks to Krystal muddling with the paperwork), she’d slowly been acclimating to life outside a rigorously controlled organization. Arch, on the other hand, generally only popped in for brief stints between missions and often took his meals in his room—though, given that he was training Albert, and therefore Neil by extension, I had somewhat expected him to make it down. Some manner of Agency task had probably demanded his attention instead, since he was employed by the same people as Krystal. Neither of them spoke much about work due to the secretive nature of what they did, but I was slowly piecing enough together to suspect that despite their both being called “Agent,” they had a lot of differences in their actual jobs.

“Charlotte, when Lillian asked for me to come by, was she hunched over a large stack of documents or swearing at her laptop?”

“The latter. It’s actually quite nostalgic. I haven’t heard some of those curses being thrown about for decades.” Charlotte smiled, looking briefly wistful for the tenants who had constructed her a very long time ago. “But she didn’t break anything in frustration, so I’d say she is making progress.”

Well, that made the choice of who to see first simple. Lillian was working on her study materials and some small-scale assignments I’d handed over, so she was likely calling me for help. The woman was a hard worker and a dedicated student, making tremendous progress in learning the trade of accounting, but no one could master the craft without occasional bits of guidance. If she was asking for assistance, then it must be something quite difficult. It was probably better if I encouraged her to take the night off for Neil’s party and deal with the issue tomorrow. But even that might require some convincing, as she was determined to get her credentials as soon as possible. Better to start with Arch, who was nothing if not quick to the point in every conversation. The term “blunt” had been bandied about more than once when discussing him. So had “heartless” and “robot,” although I’d found that Arch did have some sentimentality in him. It just required a keen eye and

lots of patience to spot.

“Tell Lillian I’ll be there in ten minutes, and let Arch know I’m on my way, please.” While I didn’t see Charlotte so much as move a step, I knew versions of her were relaying the message as I headed over to Neil. Although the two of us had never gotten along as well as I did with most of the others, it would have been rude to slip away without so much as even a cursory greeting to the birthday boy.

I waited my turn behind Bubba, who delivered a handshake so hearty I feared for the necromancer’s bones. He finally finished, stepping to the side and helping himself to a cold silver can from the tray held by one of Charlotte’s waiter forms. Stepping closer, I met Neil’s eyes and stuck out my own hand. “Happy birthday. And welcome to the official world of adulthood.”

Despite the fact that I’d been looking at Neil, I couldn’t help but notice a brief expression flash across Albert’s nearby face. The look stood out to me not because of its severity, but rather its strangeness. Albert was a perpetually cheerful, upbeat person, which is what made the flicker of sadness in his eyes seem so alien.

Before I could dwell or comment on it, Neil had taken my hand and given it a shake. “Thanks, Fred.” Then the exchange was done, and I moved away to let Neil begin partaking in the festivities. As the party moved toward the dining room, a once more smiling Albert with them, I headed upstairs to see Arch.

Looking back, I should have been wondering why he would summon me to a meeting, but my mind was stuck in that moment with Albert. Besides, I was assuming this would be more non-news from the Agency. When I’d officially founded my parahuman clan to fend off the aggression from other vampires moving into town, I’d also signed Fletcher Accounting Services up to do freelance work with the Agency. It was a dangerous alliance that wouldn’t endear me to most other parahumans, but it had given me and my friends a measure of protection from the House of Turva. Yet, in the months since I’d signed on, no work had come. Every time I asked Arch, he’d merely told me that my application was under review. I expected more of the same as I knocked on his slightly ajar door and walked through, but at a glance, I knew I was wrong.

Arch was zipping up a small duffel bag, one I’d seen him carry with him when leaving many a time. He was dressed in layers, as usual, and I knew from experience that hidden amidst those folds of cloth were weapons designed to take down countless types of creatures. Of all my friends, Arch was the only one whose parahuman nature remained a mystery to me. No one talked about it, especially not Arch, and I never asked. Partly out of politeness, partly because I suspected that I wouldn’t like the answer. Sometimes, in the parahuman world, ignorance was preferable. I’d learned

that lesson by asking an ancient dragon one too many questions.

“Charlotte, would you mind putting my gift for Neil with the others?” Arch nodded to a small package in dark purple wrapping paper on his dresser. “If you know where Fred’s is, get that too. I’m afraid we’re going to miss the party.”

“Do I get to ask why we’ll be missing it?” I hadn’t moved from the doorway, but that didn’t stop Charlotte from walking by me and scooping up Arch’s gift. She said nothing as she made her way past; although this time I did step aside for her. Charlotte was an expert at knowing when to be a landlord, a friend, or a house.

“I think you’ve already put it together,” Arch told me. “But if you want confirmation: word came down a few minutes ago. Your freelance application has been processed; it’s time to move on to the interview and skills portion.”

“Which means meeting them in person.” Somewhere, in the back of my mind, I think a part of me had grown accustomed to the months of being put off, convincing myself that I’d be able to stay in limbo forever, protected by an alliance that I never had to put in work to maintain. It was a silly notion, and I’d recognized it as such even when I held it, yet that didn’t stop it from stinging ever so slightly as the idea was unceremoniously destroyed by Arch. “I’ll get my briefcase and laptop. Are we heading into town? If so, I’d like to pop by my apartment and change into something more professional.”

Truth be told, I wasn’t in what most would call a casual ensemble, with my button-down shirt, khakis, and sweater vest, but if I was meeting someone in the Agency, I felt like I should go for a full suit. Arch stared at me for several seconds before shaking his head.

“No, Fred, we’re not going into town. I just told you, I’m taking you for an interview and skills test.”

“Right, which I took to mean that there’s a representative in Winslow, probably staying at Richard’s or something. I mean, it’s not like they’d invite me to their actual offices, the locations of which I assume are national secrets.”

Arch lifted the duffel bag and tossed it easily over his shoulder, a show of surprising strength for his short stature and slight frame. “Our fiscal people tend to stay at the offices, and they’re the ones who are interviewing you. That means it’s my job to take you to them. You were right about one thing, though.” Reaching into his pocket, Arch produced a thick swath of dark fabric and tossed it over to me. I snared it from mid-air and unfolded the item, quickly realizing what I’d been handed. It was a hood to cover my head, and based on the small arcane runes woven into the fabric, I had a hunch it was strong enough to block out even my enhanced senses.

“The location is a secret. Once we’re in the plane, I’ll need you to put

that on.”

Folding the hood carefully and tucking it into my pocket, I considered the situation. “May I have half an hour to help Lillian and say my goodbyes? I’d like to at least explain why I’m ditching out on Neil’s party.”

“No one down there needs an explanation, Fred. They know what a summons from the Agency means.” Arch glanced down at his watch and stared at it for several long moments. “But I did pack fast, so I can give you fifteen minutes to grab your stuff and say whatever you’d like to everyone.”

“Thank you, Arch.” I turned and bolted from the room, well aware that, as soon as those fifteen minutes were up, I’d be out the door whether I liked it or not. Still, I appreciated even the small window of time I’d been handed. Like I said earlier, Arch *does* have a heart; you just have to pay close attention to see it peeking out.



2.

The one upside to the hood was that it blocked out the bickering. And that was, truly, an amazing accomplishment. While I rarely have use for them, outside of sniffing the bouquet from a fine glass of Pinot Noir, vampire senses are quite exceptional, so it was all the more impressive that, immediately after donning it, I could no longer hear Krystal squabbling with Arch.

The fifteen minutes of goodbyes had been relatively painless, although ten of those were spent helping Lillian along in her work and rapidly setting up plans for how she and Albert were to handle any business that might come in over the next few days. Theoretically, I'd still have email, but when dealing with parahumans, it pays to put contingency plans in place. Better they be able to let inquisitive clients know I was temporarily away on business than have people who trusted me with their finances think I'd suddenly skipped town.

It wasn't until Arch and I went downstairs to let the party know we would be leaving early that we hit something of an issue. Most took the news with immediate acceptance; they understood that when the Agency called, it was unwise to refuse. Especially for someone who needed their protection as much as we all did. The House of Turva hadn't taken the slights against them lightly, and the moment they saw a weakness, they'd pounce on it. While originally, that would have only impacted me, everyone had signed on to join my clan—albeit without my knowledge—which meant they'd be targets as well. The Agency and some official alliances with friends were all that kept the angry vampires at bay.

Krystal, however, had not reacted well to the news of my being suddenly pulled away. She was . . . unhappy that the order to bring me in had come to Arch rather than her, although, given our personal relationship, I understood why her higher-ups would make that call. Not that I said anything to that effect, mind you. I may have put myself in life-threatening situations several times over the past few years, but I wasn't so suicidal as to disagree with Krystal when she was angry. In the end, she'd decided to accompany us. Arch had voiced his disapproval, to which Krystal had responded by pointing out that she was an agent and could go to headquarters whenever she damn well pleased. There were also a lot of suggestions as to what Arch should do with his opinions—most of which centered around him shoving them places—but I'll omit those for the sake of brevity and tact.

Once we were finally out of the house, it was a short car ride to a private air strip where a plane was waiting for us. I'd have been impressed by such opulent transportation for a mere interview if I hadn't seen how free the Agency was with providing air transport in the past. If they did actually bring me on to do some finance work, one of the first things I'd suggest would be

having agents fly commercial more often. Surely not every trip demanded such expensive privacy.

After that, there was nothing to recall but darkness. Nearly every sense I had was completely muted, which was actually a rather strange experience in itself. Sort of like being asleep while staying lucid. The one change I was able to register came during the flight, when I felt a familiar hand lay itself in mine and interweave our fingers. Krystal had apparently switched from arguing with Arch to comforting me. I can't say how long we were like that, or even how much time passed at all. Floating in darkness, it becomes difficult to keep track of things like minutes drifting by. There was simply the void around me, the hand in mine, and the occasional shake as the plane moved along.

Then, without warning, the plane bounced twice, and I realized that we had landed. I waited for someone to help me up, no doubt guiding me to a car that would bring us from the airport to our location. Instead, the plane rolled along the ground for a while before finally coming to a full stop. Moments later, my hood was peeled away and I found myself peering into Krystal's lovely brown eyes.

"Hey, Freddy. We're here."

I looked around at the plane and out the windows, not entirely sure what to expect. From what I could see, we were in a hangar, although it might have just as easily been a giant metal warehouse. There were no windows, just a closed set of heavy steel doors where the plane had presumably come through, along with a smaller matching set at the other side of the building. Outside, Arch was talking to someone in a pilot's uniform as he smoked his way through what would in no way be his only cigarette of the day. Putting it all together, I did some mental calculations and positively reeled.

"Krystal, does your agency employ the use of a private air strip?"

"Sure do. They used to just land at nearby ones, but building one on site made things a lot easier for all of us."

"Do you have any idea how much that must cost? I mean, for as many planes as you'd need to be flying to make it pragmatic, the fuel costs alone—"

I stopped talking, not because I'd run out of things to say on the topic, but rather because Krystal had leaned in and kissed me firmly on the mouth. We stayed like that for several long seconds before she pulled away. "You talk about numbers and costs a lot when you get nervous, you know. But you don't need to be scared. This is my office, Freddy. It's a place of business. They just want to see if you've got the chops to be a useful freelancer."

"Given that our tentative status is all that's keeping some very unhappy vampires at bay, I'd say this situation comes with ample reason to be

nervous.” Looking down, I realized our hands were still intertwined. In the rush of my senses coming back, I’d failed to notice that. “What if I mess this up? Failing to land a client is one thing; falling short here could come with very dire consequences.”

“First off, even if something did go wrong today, which it won’t, the House of Turva still can’t risk moving against you. Not with Richard’s people being official House of Fred allies. And secondly, are you really worried about *this*? Come on, Freddy. I know you lack confidence, but this is accounting. Even you have to admit that this is your jam. The booming business is proof enough.”

“I’m good with numbers, not people, and Arch specifically called this an interview.” Taking a deep breath—a habit that helps settle one’s nerves regardless of whether or not they actually breathe—I rose from my seat. “But I suppose I’m going to have to try and make a good impression anyway.”

Krystal got up from her chair as well, finally letting go of my hand as she smoothed the wrinkles in her red blouse. “Just be you, Freddy. That’s always been enough for us, and I’m sure it will go over well in the interviews. After all, it’s not like you’ll be interviewing with agents. You’re going to talk to other numbers people. I bet you’ll mention investment accounts, and they’ll get tingly, and by the time this is done, all of you will be overhauling the agency’s pension plan.”

“You get pensions?”

“Shit yeah. Government job, Freddy. We get all kinds of perks. But lots of free time isn’t among them, so shake a leg.” Krystal swatted me on the rear, and the two of us headed down the plane’s folded-out stairs.

By the time we reached the ground, Arch was already on his second cigarette and the pilot had wandered off. Wordlessly, Arch nodded as we approached, and then led us to the small set of doors at the far end of the building. They were metal, incredibly thick with no handle in sight. Instead, there was only a small keypad to the left side of them. Arch punched in a few numbers, and seconds later, the soft crackle of an intercom filled the air.

“Agent Davenport escorting Fredrick Fletcher for an interview and skills test, as assigned.” Arch paused, taking a long drag from his smoke. “Also, Agent Jenkins is here.”

I was still trying to process the facts that a) I’d never heard Arch’s last name before, and b) it was Davenport, when the doors began sliding open. They parted to reveal a short hallway that ended in another set of identical metal doors. Interestingly, this short stretch of interior was painted a crisp white color, which made all the runes and arcane scribblings covering every inch stand out all the more. Some of it I semi-recognized from glimpses at Amy and Neil’s books, or the night I saw dragon magic woven around a building, but by far the majority was completely alien. Arch stepped in

immediately, while Krystal waited for me to take my first step before following. No sooner had we entered than the doors behind us sealed shut.

“I’m guessing this is the Agency’s version of airport security scanners?” I ventured.

“If the airport scanners were designed to detect enchantments, shape-changers, illusions, or a myriad of other tricks some parahuman might use to try and sneak their way in, then yes, it would be just like them.” Arch finished his cigarette and dropped it into the small box he always kept on hand for disposing of butts and ashes. They probably didn’t let him smoke indoors here either, which explained the surly response. Arch had a tendency to get grumpy when he had to quit smoking even for a brief period of time, which happened with exceptional regularity. Charlotte had created a smoking lounge in the manor just for Arch, although occasionally Richard, Bubba, and Krystal would adjourn there to puff on oversized cigars.

Whatever magic was working around us, to me it felt like we were simply standing in a hallway with weird writing all over the place. Evidently, and thankfully, none of us tripped any alarms, and soon the second set of doors began to part. This time, there wasn’t another hallway full of magical symbols awaiting us. In fact, it looked almost conspicuously mundane on the other side. Fluorescent lights, cheap gray carpeting, and a white tiled ceiling made it identical to countless other offices all throughout the nation. The only thing that stood out was the man waiting for us on the other side. He was lean, almost gaunt really, with a head so perfectly bald and pale that it seemed like someone had painted a face on an egg and set it atop a scarecrow in a suit. His smile was surprisingly affable though, and the man greeted us as we stepped out from the magic-scanning hallway.

“Agent Davenport, Agent Jenkins, good to see you both again. Mr. Fletcher, it’s a pleasure to make your acquaintance. Your reputation as an accountant precedes you. My name is Roderick Knox, and I am the head of the Agency’s finance division. I’m also the man who will be interviewing you today.”

3.

“Can I get you anything? Water? Blood? I know the summons came out of the blue, so I’ll understand if you need to eat.” Roderick’s office was substantial. Not the biggest I’d ever laid eyes on, but certainly sizable enough to mark his importance to the Agency. It was also unexpectedly comforting. The sight of file cabinets, stacks of folders, and an out-of-date desktop were familiar hallmarks of my corporate accounting days, which made me feel far more at home than I normally would have in a secret location for a government agency.

“No, thank you. As a rule, I always keep some emergency blood on hand for just such occasions.” Reaching into my briefcase, I held up the enchanted flask I’d picked up in Boarback, Texas. Between having to run from a vampire hunter and getting stuck for days in the mansion of a pair of bickering mage siblings, I’d discovered it was prudent to always have more nutrition on hand than might seem necessary.

Roderick took note of the flask and sat down at his desk, which was both spacious and impossible to see under the thick layer of documents covering it. “Prepared for the unexpected. I like that. It’s an attitude that will serve you well if you work with us.”

“In working with parahuman clients, I’ve found preparation and redundancy to be indispensable tools.”

“Yes, let’s talk about your prior work.” Roderick reached into a drawer under his desk and pulled out a thick, cream-colored folder, the same brand I kept in my own office for compiling documents. Despite the folders being an industry standard, I suddenly felt a curious kinship with the bald man before me. Just like parahumans, accountants have a culture of their own.

“In life, you did good work. Always precise, but never especially aggressive in terms of taking on new responsibilities. Post-death, however, you’ve shown far more initiative and entrepreneurial spirit.” The pages fluttered within their folder as Roderick flipped through them. “You founded Fletcher Accounting Services, gained a Certified Public Parahuman License, and almost immediately began taking on a wealth of new clients, many of whom were high profile. Very high profile, in a few cases.”

Although I rarely dwelled on it, Roderick was right that some of my friends held stations far above my own. He was probably talking about Ainsley and Zane, a pair of mages I’d helped sort out the inheritance left by their father. “Are you referring to the Clover siblings?”

“No, wealthy as they are, that duo is hardly the most prestigious account on your record. I was referring to your work with Gideon, the King of the West,” Roderick said.

“Ah. To be fair, Gideon never directly engaged my services. I was

called in to work for Richard Alderson, and handling Gideon's finances was simply part of the package. It wouldn't feel proper for me to claim him as a client."

Roderick gave me a long, careful look before flipping to the next file. He was clearly searching my face for something, but I wasn't entirely sure what it might be. If nothing else, I took comfort in the fact that, so far, I'd told only the truth, so if he was hunting for signs of falsehoods, he would come up short.

"Proper or not, he's part of your client history," Roderick said at last. "As are the aforementioned Clover siblings, Richard Alderson and many of his therians, the enchanted home that houses two of our agents, and countless other parahumans. To be honest, Mr. Fletcher, I'd heard your name well before the application to work as a freelancer ever came across my desk. There was some worry from up top that you were up to something, so I was asked to look over your paper trail for any discrepancies. What I found instead was a meticulous, well-prepared set of documents on every occasion. You do fine work, and from the testimonials we've gathered, all of your business practices are aboveboard."

"Beg pardon, but what do you mean by testimonials? I very much hope you haven't been bothering my clients about this." I'll admit, this objection might seem a touch petty; however, my time as a CPPA had cast a light onto just how highly many parahumans valued their privacy. Especially where the Agency was concerned. If they'd been hunting down and pestering people that had used my company, then word would spread, and within a year, I'd likely be filing for bankruptcy.

"Only the ones we already had official dealings with," Roderick assured me. "As a rule, we tend to let the parahumans who want their distance from us have it, at least so long as they don't do anything that requires reprimanding."

Not the most reassuring of statements, but it was something. "That is somewhat reassuring. So, my reputation is good, and you've evaluated my work, which means you know I'm competent—"

Roderick lifted a single finger into the air to halt me before I could continue. "I know the *work* I've seen is competent. Beyond that, really, the work is exceptional. Whether you are actually the one doing it or not has yet to be determined."

It took me several moments to fully process what Roderick was suggesting. "Hold on, do you think I've been acting as the face of the company, only to shove the actual accounting onto someone else? How does that make sense, given my career in life? For that matter, who would choose *me* as the face of a company?" I gestured to myself for good measure. While I don't find myself especially hideous, I was self-aware enough to know I

hardly came off as smooth or classically handsome, and my taste in clothing wasn't entirely aligned with what was trendy and hip.

"Mr. Fletcher, as a rule, the Agency doesn't assume competence when looking for scams or tricks. Just because a plan is bad doesn't mean someone might not try to pull it. And this one does make a certain amount of sense. As a vampire and former accountant, you make the perfect front. Strong enough to deal with more powerful parahumans as a peer, experienced enough to sell the story. That said, on a personal level, I think you're on the up and up. Part of my parahuman nature allows me to have a keen sense for liars, and your words ring consistently true. However, we are a branch of the government, and doing work for us would allow you access to highly restricted documents. We would be remiss if we didn't do our due diligence in making sure you were the real deal."

"I . . . suppose I understand." I didn't love the implied accusation, but Arch had been upfront about the fact that this was an interview *and* skills assessment. Really, the whole situation was rather ideal. If the hardest hurdle I had to clear was proving I knew my stuff as an accountant, that was something I could do. The interview was the harder part, and as Roderick closed the folder and stowed it in his desk once more, it became clear that our chat was winding down.

"I had a feeling you would." The sound of another opening drawer came, and this time, Roderick held the contents out to me. It was a small stack of papers, which I accepted and began looking over while he continued. "Those our standard non-disclosures, although I'd still recommend fully reading each page, as what the Agency considers standard and what the rest of the world uses are far from identical. The long and short of it is that, from this point on, if you share any of the information you see with someone who lacks proper clearance—which would essentially be all non-agents—there will be serious consequences."

I flipped ahead a little to see what Roderick was referring to and found myself thankful that, as a vampire, I had a naturally pale skin tone. Otherwise, the blood might have visibly drained from my face as I read over what happened to those who broke the non-disclosure. "Serious consequences" was accurate, but it somewhat belied the harshness of what was waiting for those who spilled Agency secrets. Even if I didn't go pale, my expression still evidently betrayed my concern.

"I realize the penalties are a bit stiff. Try to understand, this Agency is tasked with keeping parahumans in check and obedient to their treaties. Our reputation for efficiency and ruthlessness is a huge part of that. If we had people walking around, babbling on about things they shouldn't, it would undercut our image. And that is something we simply cannot tolerate."

Making a mental note to never talk about my freelance work, even in

general terms, to anyone, *ever*, I pulled a pen from my pocket and began etching my signature onto the document. Harsh as the penalties were, they still only applied to those who told tales they shouldn't. As a professional accountant, I'd already known the importance of confidentiality and discretion in my trade. Upping the stakes for failure was scary, true, but on a fundamental level, it really didn't change anything about my job.

"Mind if I ask you a question, Mr. Knox?"

"Please, call me Roderick," he replied. "And by all means, feel free to ask whatever you like."

"Then I insist you call me Fred, as nearly everyone else already does." I paused, rereading a small section twice, then finally initialing next to it. "Forgive me if this is pressing too much, but I'm curious. You use a lot of 'we' terms when referring to the Agency and its employees; am I to understand that even the finance department and its workers are considered to be agents?"

The smile stretched across Roderick's face slowly, like a cat that had just woken from a long nap in sunshine. "No, the majority are just people who are good with numbers. I'm something of an exception, in that I had skills that made me useful in the field while also adept at handling finances. I spent a few decades working as an agent, but decided to leave field work behind and pursue something a little more stable. Don't worry, Fred, no one is expecting you to do what Agent Jenkins or Agent Davenport do. We'd just be looking to lean on you in hectic times, as even this department can get flooded, and perhaps do the occasional external audit or finance assessment."

"An agent and an accountant. And here I thought I was the oddball for choosing this job as a vampire."

"There aren't many who straddle both lines, and most of them are Greeds like me." It took several seconds for Roderick to notice the blank stare on my face as I waited for an explanation. "Fred, have you never dealt with half-demons before?"

For a moment, I nearly broke the pen in my hand. The only thing related to hellfire I'd encountered was Krystal, after she'd had her throat slit, and that had been a truly terrifying experience. As I understood it, Krystal's soul played prison to a powerful, evil entity that had been sealed in her bloodline generations ago. If she died, it died, so it manifested when she was gravely injured, turning her from functionally human to one of the most dangerous creatures in the world, albeit temporarily. Thankfully, I remembered that Krystal had very specifically referred to what she had as a devil, whereas demons were lesser creatures.

"Half-demons would be new to me. I've never met one in Winslow," I admitted.

"With Agent Jenkins there, you likely wouldn't have. Many of my



kind avoid her type out of instinct, even if they don't understand why." He paused, and for the first time since we'd met, I could see Roderick choosing his next words carefully, rather than letting the conversation flow. "Half-demons can, if they wish, live as normal humans. So long as we don't feed our demon-selves, we are functionally mortal. However, if we do allow our demon sides to feed, then we gain strength, longevity, toughness, the usual parahuman boons, along with some perks depending on our exact nature. What among the seven deadly sins is food for us depends on our demonic heritage. Mine, for example, is the sin of greed. Hanging around casinos or stock brokerages will fill me up in no time. That's why we tend to refer to ourselves by our natures: thus I am known as a Greed."

"Wow, that is a new one by me." I stared at him for a little longer than was necessary, still watching for a pair of horns or a burst of hellfire to spring forth. Instead, there was just a patient expression waiting for me to finish my paperwork. With a few more signatures, I closed my pen and handed the stack of documents back over to Roderick.

"The parahuman world is a wide one, and if you work with us, you'll learn more about it than you ever would have in Colorado." Roderick checked the pages over, then tucked them back into his desk. "For now, though, I'm going to get everything prepared. When it's ready, we'll take you to a designated room and give you some sample work to do. Assuming your skills live up to your reputation, your freelancing application will be approved. It will take about half an hour, so I'd advise you to drink some blood and maybe grab a coffee. I'm sure Agent Jenkins will show you the way. When I'm ready, I'll have Agent Davenport bring you down."

Roderick rose from his desk, so I took the cue and followed suit. "Good luck, Fred. I truly hope you are able to join us, even if only as a freelancer."

Well, at least that made two of us, even if we wanted the same outcome for very different reasons.

4.

“Come look, this is my desk!” Krystal dragged me across the cheap gray carpet, nearly spilling my newly acquired cup of coffee from the modest break room, toward a large room full of desks. It was, as I recalled from my corporate days, referred to as an open-concept office, which always felt to me like a fun way to say that a company didn’t want to spend the money on cubicle walls. Then again, given how rarely Krystal ever actually seemed to visit her home office, it did make a certain amount of sense that they wouldn’t want to dedicate too much floor space to agents.

We moved briskly through the largely empty room, as apparently, she wasn’t the only agent who spent most of her time in the field. The lone exception was a tall woman in the back, so broad-shouldered she could have been Richard’s cousin, and a pale male several feet away that I instantly recognized as a fellow vampire. That explained why there hadn’t been any windows since we walked in, at least. They had to keep the place parahuman friendly at all hours of the day.

“This is me.” Krystal pointed to a desk that was almost identical to every other one on the floor, save for the fact that it was messier and had three picture frames bunched up near her computer’s monitor. The first was of a couple I might not have recognized if Krystal and I didn’t share a hometown, but I’d seen her mother and father often enough to know who I was looking at. They lined up a little too well with my memory, actually, which meant the photo was an old one. Not surprising, since her mother had passed away while Krystal was in college. The next photo was filled with familiar faces. It was inside Charlotte Manor, and featured every one of our friends. Even Charlotte was there, dressed in a festive flapper outfit.

“Is this from the night we drove off Petre?”

“You know it. Everyone was there and dressed snazzy, so it seemed like a good picture for the desk,” Krystal explained.

My eyes moved to the final photo in the line, and had I been human, I’d have blushed so thoroughly that the other vampire’s stomach would have rumbled from the amount of blood in my face. This was a picture of Krystal and I, taken mid-kiss. Given the angle, she’d clearly held up her phone to snap a photo, doing it so slyly I hadn’t even noticed.

“I would have posed for a regular photograph.”

“Freddy, you always look stiff when we try to take regular pictures. I wanted one where you were you. And that meant getting your guard down.” She leaned in and whispered the next part in my ear. “But if you want to do a reshoot, I’m always game.”

Although my embarrassment deepened, and I frantically glanced around to see if we’d been overheard, I still appreciated what Krystal was

doing. She knew I was nervous, and was trying to keep me from getting too in my head. Not that she wouldn't have done the same thing in other circumstances—I often suspected my public shyness toward affection was why she loved teasing me so much—however, she might have been a bit less overt normally.

“Maybe when we get home,” I replied. “At the moment, I’m afraid all I’d be thinking about is whatever test awaits me.”

“Is that a challenge? Because if you think I can’t take your mind off numbers, then—”

The sound of running footsteps interrupted, followed by a familiar voice yelling, “Krys!” And then Krystal had a pair of toned, slender arms wrapped around her in a loose hug. June’s speed was impressive; I’d literally just scanned the room and seen no sign of her. Then again, as a half-fey, she had more than a few advantages in her favor. Once she released my girlfriend, I noticed that June didn’t look quite the same as before. Aside from the external alterations, such as her favoring jeans and sneakers rather than overalls this time, her eyes had also changed color. Before, they were a lavender that worked well with her blue-white hair, but today they gleamed a deep cerulean color. I hadn’t realized those with fey blood could shift such things, although that was hardly surprising given how little I knew about parahumans overall. There were just so many types of us, and each with our own quirks and traits.

“Hey, Fred, good to see you too.” June gave me a brief hug—nothing like the embrace she’d thrust upon Krystal, but still a steep improvement from our first time meeting at CalcuCon.

“What are you doing here? Get wrangled into filing some reports?” Krystal asked.

“No, we just got our assignments. There’s a nest of—” June’s words halted, her eyes darting to me. It began to dawn on me that I was something of an invader to the agents here, my presence restricting their ability to speak freely. After seeing the non-disclosure that Roderick had given me, I could see how seriously they all took confidentiality. “A nest of bad things, in a place, that need clearing out,” she finished. “What about you? You never come to the office unless you have to, and I don’t recall Fred having clearance.”

“He’s applying to do some freelance accounting work,” Krystal explained. “And I came along for support. Well, support, and to make sure he didn’t panic and lock himself in a broom closet. Mostly support, though.”

Another set of footsteps reached my ears—as well as Krystal and June’s, since they turned to look behind me. Both of them had instantaneous reactions: Krystal’s relaxed posture turned stiff, and her cheerful face grew unexpectedly harsh. For her part, June merely went from happy to

uncomfortable. Even before I started to turn, I already knew what would be awaiting me there. I am, as indicated by job and history, good with numbers, and this wasn't a difficult situation to add up.

June had been saying "we" a lot during her description of activities. That meant she was here with someone. I didn't know a lot of agents, but I could think of one who would garner such reactions from these two. The likeliest candidate to go on a mission with June that would cause Krystal to suddenly turn harsh was June's own brother: the agent who also happened to be Krystal's ex-fiancé.

Sure enough, the man behind me was definitely related to June. Same blue-white hair, same inhuman beauty, with flawless skin and powerful bone structure. Aside from gender, the biggest difference between the two was eye color, as he currently had a deep orange, and fashion-sense. While June seemed to favor comfort and function, like Krystal, this man was wearing an impeccable suit that had clearly been tailored specifically to fit his lean form. While I'd known since meeting June that Krystal's old flame was a fellow half-fey, and therefore would be far more handsome than any human could equal, it was still intimidating to meet him in person. This was the sort of man Krystal had dated before me?

"Fred, let me introduce my brother: September Windbrook." June had snapped out of her momentary awkward coma and stepped over next to the newcomer. "Bro, this is Fredrick Fletcher. He's here to interview for accounting work."

"Mr. Fletcher. A pleasure to meet you." September offered his hand, which I accepted. To my surprise, I got a normal handshake in return. No squeezing or posturing, just perfect politeness. I hadn't known what to expect from this fellow, but no one I knew who'd met him had seemed especially fond of the guy. Still, if he was willing to keep it civil, I certainly wasn't going to object.

We finished our handshake, and his eyes turned to Krystal. No . . . that wasn't quite true. His eyes passed over the desk and lingered for the barest of moments on the picture of she and I, then they continued on to Krystal. "Agent Jenkins. You look well."

"Go fuck yourself, Tem."

And there went the plan to keep things civil.

He stared at Krystal for a long moment, then turned to June. "We should get going. The case is time sensitive. Mr. Fletcher, good luck on your interview. Agent Jenkins, take care of yourself." With that, he began walking once more, neatly sidestepping Arch, who was making his way into the room as September left.

"Sorry, I should have warned you he was here too. I just . . . sometimes it slips my mind that it's an issue," June said.

Krystal grabbed her fellow agent and pulled her close, giving the woman a tight hug. “Don’t worry about it. Ever. His shit has nothing to do with you and me, okay?”

“Thanks.” June gave Krystal a hug back, then extricated herself. “I have to go, though. September is the one who got the plane, and he might not wait for me. The nest thing really is time sensitive.”

“I understand,” Krystal told her. “Give me a ring when you get back. Maybe we can meet up in Winslow. You’d love the crowd I’m running with now. Never a dull moment with that group.”

“Sounds like a plan.” June lingered for a moment longer, giving me a brief nod, and then darted off after her brother.

Arch, using the void of diplomacy that allowed him to ignore social cues in that way that only he really could, walked right by her and approached us. “Fred, they’re ready for you.”

Moments prior, I’d been dreading Arch’s arrival, mind entirely occupied with fears, most of which were quite irrational, about what sort of test the Agency would put me through. The silver lining to our encounter with June and September, however, was that it had driven such worries completely out of mind.

I leaned in, forcing away my shyness for a brief moment, and gave Krystal a kiss on the lips. “I’ll try not to take too long.”

“Take as much time as you need, Freddy. Go kick the shit out of this test.” Krystal pulled me in and kissed me back, although hers was far less gentle or brief. “I’m fine. It takes more than seeing some asshole from my past to rattle my cage. My life is too damn good to let dipshits like Tem bring me down.”

With nothing else to say and time burning, we finally stepped away from each other. “Arch, please lead the way. It seems I’ve got some accounting to do.”

5.

The room itself was reminiscent of the hall we'd gone through when entering the building: vacant space surrounded by stark white walls with a few arcane scribblings painted in seemingly erratic intervals. It was empty, save only for a simple desk with a white top and a folder holding a dense stack of papers. My instructions were the height of simplicity: do the work. No time limit, although I assumed my speed would be part of the equation as much as my precision. They wanted to see if I really did have the skills to succeed at the jobs they might hand me, and that meant testing every aspect of what my accounting entailed.

Rest easy, dear reader, because I am not going to bore you with the details of what was in that folder, both because I am utterly certain you have no desire to read the fine fiscal details, and because, even now, I make it a point never to air Agency business. All you need to know is that the work was complex, taxing, and tough enough to make for a thrilling challenge. Nearly every section dealt with some manner of the tax code for various parahumans, and without my usual access to reference books, it took all I had to work through them. If I hadn't spent the last year constantly dealing with the subject matter, there was no chance I'd have been able to complete it. Which, looking back, was almost certainly the point of the test in the first place.

It's hard to say how long I was in that room for; with no clocks on the wall and my mind absorbed by the task at hand, time seemed an unnecessary concept. This was, in truth, a somewhat common occurrence for me at home as well. It's surprising how easy it is to lose one's self in work without the biological needs of the living to act as regular interruptions.

All I knew was that, as I finished entering numbers in the final column, the door creaked open and Roderick made his way through. Holding out his hand, he accepted the file wordlessly as I made one last pen stroke and offered it over. Silence reigned as Roderick perused my efforts, turning the pages slowly, scouring each one. Perhaps it was meant to be an intimidation technique, an oppressive silence to force any falsehoods from my mouth as time wore on. However, I actually rather enjoyed the quiet. It was an element I was accustomed to, yet had managed to get less and less of as my life had become filled with more chaotic people. Besides, I had nothing to hide, and had done my best on the task given to me. If I fell short of their requirements, then I simply wasn't good enough. Terrifying as the consequences of that would be, it didn't change the fact that nothing I did now would change the outcome. So I sat, meeting Roderick's silence with peaceful quiet of my own, until he was nearly to the end of the pages.

"Remarkable." He ran his finger down the page, no doubt adding up my totals in his head to double check them. "I'll admit, Fred, I initially had

my doubts about you. As a whole, vampires don't tend to go in for this sort of work, so when rumors about one not only doing it, but doing it well, began to circulate, I had some misgivings. Your association with two of our agents, to say nothing of your more prestigious clients, certainly painted the picture of a man amassing connections and influence while playing the role of a harmless number cruncher. But even if that's the case, you've certainly gone the extra mile. We included plenty of obscure parahuman loopholes in here, things you never would have encountered as a living accountant. To have done such good work on this document speaks to a man who is pursuing his craft ardently and constantly improving."

"I'd like to be more offended by the suspicions, but given my dealings with other vampires, I have to admit I understand. Although, perhaps the reason you don't get more of my kind working as accountants is more due to the clan system than an actual aversion to the job."

Roderick paused, looking up from the papers for the first time since he'd gotten them. "That's an interesting sentiment, coming from someone who just founded his own clan."

"A move born of necessity," I explained. "Given the thoroughness of your research on me, I'd be foolish not to assume you know what happened between myself and the House of Turva. But in dealing with them, I also saw what life was like for other vampires, the ones who don't get abandoned by their makers and left to their own devices. And when I did, for the very first time, I felt a sense of gratitude to Quinn, monster that he was. If I'd been made normally, then I would have been put into one of those clans. My own goals, talents, and desires would have become secondary; I would have become a cog in their machine, serving the clan's greater goals."

"You got all that from a couple of meetings?" Roderick asked.

"Much of it, yes. But some came from speaking to my new employee, Lillian, over these past few months. Lillian, a fellow vampire, who, when freed from the oppressive rules of her original clan, chose to take on the same trade as me of her own volition. Perhaps the reason you don't get more vampire accountants, or botanists, or data analysts, or any other manner of more mundane jobs, is because they aren't permitted to pursue jobs they might like to."

Silence fell upon us once more as Roderick turned the final few pages and snapped the folder shut. "Not every clan is the House of Turva, Fred. Some allow their members a great deal more freedom. But all of them do demand a high level of fealty, and most are greatly concerned with image and reputation. We know the system is archaic; most parahuman systems are. Change usually only happens between generations, so when people live as long as we do, it is a far slower process. It does happen, however. You're proof of that."

“I highly doubt I’m the first vampire to be abandoned and take up a less than impressive career,” I said.

“No, but you *are* the first to allow non-vampires into your clan. As founding members, no less. It was a bold decision, one that sent ripples through the parahuman community.”

Though Roderick’s face was still placid and his tone calm, those words sent shivers through my spine. In general, I’d found that the less attention I garnered from other parahumans, the happier and less deadly my life tended to be. Me sending out ripples of any kind was dangerous, especially in a community that was probably already less than happy about my supposedly boring job tarnishing their suave image.

“Um . . . what sort of ripples?”

“Let’s just say that the Agency has gotten a few complaints challenging the authenticity of such a clan.” Roderick tucked the folder under his arm and motioned for me to get up. “But the treaties back you up, and your application paperwork was flawless. That lawyer you used did a stellar job, every *T* crossed and every *I* dotted. There are no grounds to attack your clan’s legitimacy. Some of our objectors took that news better than others.”

“I suppose I’d better really hope my test holds up then,” I said, getting out of the desk and stretching. Despite not actually getting stiff or sore, a nice stretch still felt good after a long session of work. “It sounds like that freelancer association is more important than I realized.”

“We’ll have to go over it officially, but from what I’ve seen, I can’t imagine you won’t be approved to take on some jobs for us,” Roderick told me. “That said, you know there are limits to what this business relationship can protect you from, right? Working with the Agency tends to bring down some heat on those who do it, so taking care of our freelancers is a necessity if we want to keep having them, but that doesn’t insulate you from your own actions. If you do something to earn retribution, you’ll be on your own.”

My stretching done, I made my way over to the door and pulled it open, holding it there so Roderick could pass first. Even if the official testing was over, the interview was clearly still happening, and that meant common courtesy was all the more important. “Trust me when I say that that is the furthest thing from my mind. All I want is to do my job well and keep the people I care about safe.”

Roderick narrowed his eyes for a brief moment, then shook his head. “You are either the world’s greatest liar who found a way to skirt my senses, or you’re telling the truth. All things considered, the latter seems more likely.” He walked over, pausing as he was about to pass through the door and speaking with a much softer voice than usual.

“But you aren’t the entirety of your clan, Fred. There are other people in it too, parahumans with much more colorful histories and personalities than



yours. If they do something to cause trouble, it lands on your doorstep as well. That's part of what it means to be a clan, and that's why most of them keep their members on a short leash."

"I trust everyone in the House of Fred with my life," I told him, my own voice not softened in the slightest.

"Good. That's how the head of a clan *should* feel. Just keep what I said in mind in the decades to come. There will be people who want to join what you've created, some because it offers opportunities they've never had before, but others because they want to tear it down from the inside. You made something new, something different, and that happens far less than it should in our world. How it fares, good or bad, will depend on you, the people you let in, and the choices you make. You're a leader now, Fredrick Fletcher. Never forget that, because the people looking to and at you certainly won't."

Then Roderick was through the door, back into the cheaply carpeted hall lit by fluorescent tubes. I stood in that doorway for several seconds longer, absorbing his advice fully. In truth, I hadn't really planned on founding a new kind of vampire clan; my friends had joined without my knowledge as a show of support. Planned or not though, it didn't change our situation. And worrying as Roderick's words had been, I was still grateful to have heard them.

At least like this, I knew to be wary. Sometimes, in the parahuman world, a bit of advanced warning could make the difference between success and failure. Even for those of us who just wanted to work as peaceful accountants.

6.

Krystal and Arch were both waiting for me further down the hall. I happened to see a clock as I walked by and realized that it was once again evening. Evidently, I'd been working for quite a while, if an entire day had ticked past. Before I could reach the two of them, Krystal bolted forward, wrapping her arms around me and planting a kiss that would have embarrassed me greatly if I weren't still preoccupied with Roderick's warning.

"We saw Rod already. He let us know that things looked good," she said, finally parting her lips from mine. "See, I told you there was nothing to worry about, Freddy."

As my mind was currently reeling from just how much there actually was to worry about, it took me a moment to pair the nickname she'd used with the only possible owner. "Hold on, did you just call Roderick 'Rod'?"

"Sure. I've had to work with him enough that he gets a nickname." Krystal released her hold, yet stayed at my side, taking my hand in hers once more. "I don't want to brag or anything, but I've been called in to answer for my account discrepancies and collateral damage a *lot*."

"You shouldn't want to brag," Arch pointed out. "Those are bad things."

"Look, just because you always keep up with every receipt and never get creative when handling your threats doesn't mean the rest of us wear boredom like a badge of honor." She stuck her tongue out at Arch, then patted me on the shoulder. "No offense, Freddy."

I actually hadn't taken offense right up until that moment, but it was clear Krystal was in high spirits. A little too high, if I was honest, which I suspected might be related to running into her ex during our time at headquarters. Krystal rarely let herself seem bothered or vulnerable; those moments only came when the two of us were alone, somewhere safe. Levity and sass were her defenses, just as sweater vests and numbers were mine, so I simply nodded as if I were unbothered and walked with her and Arch back to the room filled with various agents' desks.

"I've got one more meeting to attend to. After that, we can board the plane and head home." Arch didn't bother asking how we'd fill the time as he peeled off from us, aiming for a different hallway. Personally, I appreciated that he'd even let us know about the delay at all.

For Krystal's part, she led me past the room full of desks—now completely empty, as even the two workers who'd been present had apparently headed off on assignments—and to a small break room. This one lacked a coffee pot, but it did have an old soda machine hosting knock-off brands I'd never heard of before. While Winslow might have hosted a lot of specialty grocery stores, never had I glimpsed a *Philosopher Pepper* can on

its shelves. Taking a seat at one of the small round tables, she motioned for me to do the same.

“Freddy, I think I owe you an explanation for earlier. The way I greeted Tem, I mean.”

“Krystal, your history is yours. We’ve talked about this before. If you reacted too harshly to the man, then I trust you had good reason for it. You don’t owe me anything.” Although I was rather curious, since she rarely discussed her former beau, over our time together I’d learned the importance in not pushing Krystal on the emotional issues. She would get to the right places when she was ready, and I would be there waiting for her, but rushing her would do neither of us any good.

“A good reason . . .” Krystal looked past me for a moment, clearly staring into some unseen moment from her past. “Yeah, I’d say I’m not short on reasons to hate Tem. But I’ve got a lot of people I hate, or at least dislike, and I hold my tongue better around them. With Tem, there’s a purpose to being constantly abrasive, though. The guy is so concerned with diplomacy, protocol, and form—not really a shocker given the family he comes from—that it’s my way of keeping a lot of distance between us. Well, between him and I, as well as myself and who I used to be when I was with him.”

She reached into her back pocket and produced a folded photograph, setting it down on the table and sliding it carefully over toward me. “I hunted through some of my old stuff in storage while you were taking your test. Most pictures from that time got destroyed, either by the fire or me personally, but I missed a couple. Take a look.”

The trouble with a skewed sense of the unexpected from dealing with constant surprise and dangerous parahumans was that I had genuinely no idea what would be waiting for me as I unfolded the picture. Would it be Krystal standing atop a pile of skulls? Holding a pair of shotguns on some unsuspecting vampires? Drunkenly riding a therian through a convenience store? All far-fetched, of course, but my girlfriend was not in the habit of hiding things—or even feeling shame, so far as I knew. If this was something she’d buried, then it must have been quite the doozy. Steeling myself as best I could, I finally worked up the courage and looked at the photo.

To say I was initially underwhelmed would do disservice to both the word and the concept it represented. There was no scene of gore or crime, just a photo of Krystal and September standing in front of a red brick building, arms intertwined. Although, if I hadn’t known it was supposed to be Krystal, I doubt I could have recognized her. There was no scarlet stripe of red lipstick or wild mane of blonde hair. Everything about her seemed subdued. Hair carefully styled, just enough makeup to accentuate her features without being brazen, a white summer dress that was more on par with my level of modesty than the garish outfits she normally favored. More than anything, however, it

was the smile that seemed off. Krystal handled joy the same way she dealt with nearly every other emotion: enthusiastically and without reservation. The woman in the picture, on the other hand, was smiling only because a photo was being taken. It was posed, false. Hollow. Not overtly, but for anyone who knew the real Krystal, the difference was impossible to miss.

“Tem likes everything in his life carefully controlled. Well managed. Sculpted. He has a firm idea of propriety, and a keen awareness of image at all times. When I was with him, I was part of that image, and I had to be managed appropriately. And I let myself be, because I was young, and in love, and he was the first stable place I’d found in the parahuman world. So that’s why I tell Tem to shove his nice greetings up his ass when we see one another, no matter the situation. I want to remind both of us that the woman who played his games is gone for good, and I’m the one in her place. Probably not the most mature way to handle it, granted, but it works for me.”

It was a curious moment, seeing who Krystal had once been. Had I known that version of her, before this new model dragged me into the strange community I now considered home, I think I would have rather liked her. The old me and the old her would have seemed to pair well, on paper anyway. But looking at the pristine lady in the photograph now, with all Krystal and I had been through in mind, I couldn’t imagine trading away the wild woman I loved for her. Where would the fun be in that bargain? Carefully, I refolded the picture and handed it back to Krystal.

“If Tem didn’t see what a rare treasure he’d found and tried to hide your true nature, then he is, without question, the greatest fool I’ve ever shaken hands with. And I am immensely thankful for that fact, because without it, he might not have lost you, and I would have missed out on the chance to reconnect with the real Krystal Jenkins.”

She took the photograph, then rose from her chair and walked over to a nearby cabinet. From inside, Krystal removed a ceramic mug and filled it halfway up with water from the sink. That done, she walked back over and set the mug down in the center of the table before reclaiming her seat.

“Truth be told, Freddy, Tem didn’t lose me because I realized what a controlling dick he was. And deep down, I still sort of hate myself for that. I wish I’d seen that he wanted a prop more than a partner. I wish I’d had the gumption to walk away on the principle of wanting to be myself. But that’s now how it went down. I didn’t wise up until I found out he was cheating on me. Banging some fey diplomat’s daughter. He tried to explain it as a political necessity or some such nonsense, but thankfully not even this version of me was willing to wade through that much bullshit.”

“What a bastard,” I said, because based on his actions, Tem clearly was.

“Yeah, he’s a real piece of shit. At least I got to meet June out of the

whole ordeal. She's the younger sibling, so the family isn't nearly as demanding or expecting of her. Fey culture stuff. I'm glad we stayed friends, although it was touch and go for a bit after I burned down the guest house."

"Well, I can see—wait, what?"

Krystal shrugged as she reached into her front pocket and produced a familiar object: Arch's lighter. "I was still getting the hang of controlling this whole inner-demon thing. When I found out my fiancé was screwing someone else, I had a bit of a flare up in the guest house on his estate, where I was living. Probably could have put it out if I wanted to . . . but I didn't. I just threw the few pieces of my shit that I cared about in bag and left that burning beacon in the rearview mirror. Fire is supposed to be cleansing, anyway."

Tilting back the lid, Krystal struck the lighter's wheel, conjuring a small, bright flame. Moving deliberately, she ran it under the photo, which immediately caught fire and began to burn. "Remind me to give this back to Arch, not that he'll let me hang on to it for more than a few seconds once we're somewhere he can smoke again."

"I'll make sure you don't forget," I promised. "If you don't mind me asking, what happened after you drove away?"

"My training was done, so I put in a transfer request and told management I never wanted to be paired with Tem again, then buried myself in work. I focused on being a good agent, doing things my way. Figuring out what that even meant took time. That was pretty much how I burned the next few years, until we got word about some werewolves in a town where I happened to have the perfect cover." Krystal grinned as she watched the last of the photograph turn to ash, dropping it into the mug of water. "And that was where I met a man who didn't need a prop, because he was about as unconcerned with image as one could get. Plus, he was kind of cute, in a nerdy way."

"How can you say I'm unconcerned with image?" With an exaggerated, sweeping motion, I gestured to my current ensemble. "Can you not see how fashionable this sweater vest is? I'm pretty sure I spotted it in a magazine once."

"Ah yes, magazines, where people without the internet go to learn about last decade's trends," Krystal shot back. She paused, glancing down into the mug once more, then back at me. "I love you, Freddy."

"I love you, too."

Her smile deepened as she brushed the mug aside and gently rested her hand on my arm. "You'd better, because I've still got Arch's lighter, and I'm not above burning some more shit."

7.

The trip home was mercifully uneventful. When Arch's meeting finished, he found us in the break room, although how he knew to look there was a mystery to me. After that, it was back to the plane, and my head slipped into the sightless, soundless void that was the enchanted hood once again. I didn't really mind it, though. The day had been a long one, with new possibilities and unexpected revelations, so I was glad for a chance to be by myself and truly reflect.

It hadn't occurred to me when my friends were making their grand gesture to join my clan that there would be more consequences than just angering Petre and the House of Turva, but it should have. While the mistake was forgivable, the fact remained that I was still thinking like a human more than a vampire. The things I did, the people I dealt with, all of it went on for much longer than the partial century a normal lifespan occupied. Many of the beings I was dealing with had no natural expiration date, and even the parahumans who aged did so at a greatly decreased rate. The takeaway from my meeting with Roderick wasn't just how important the alliance with the Agency was for my clan, although that point had certainly been driven home. It was also that I needed to start looking at things in the long term, rather than scrambling about to solve only whatever problem was directly in front of me at the time. After all, as an Undead American, there was no telling how long I'd be around to deal with consequences from any given choice.

And as that realization hit me, I also solved the mystery of my assistant's flickering moment of sorrow.

Once we were back in Winslow, it was something of a return to normalcy. Arch assured me that I'd get official results in a few days' time, after which they would send me assignments as needed. It took even less time than expected though, as by the next dusk word had come through that I was no longer a temporary freelancer. Instead, I was an official accounting asset to the Agency, with all the protection, and obligation, that came with such an affiliation. It was good news—great, really—but I wasn't able to celebrate quite as exuberantly as I wanted. Not until I'd dealt with an issue that was technically less pressing, yet much dearer to my heart.

Three nights after my freelancing approval came in, I called Albert over to my apartment. While it no longer served as his home, or the offices of Fletcher Accounting Services, I did still do remote work out of my dwelling on occasions. Albert was accustomed to coming over to grab documents for filing or delivery, so I assumed he would think nothing of it, or the fact that I'd specifically chosen a night when Neil would have training with Amy and thus couldn't tag along.

My locks turned as Albert let himself in, the duffel bag at his side

banging against the doorframe as usual. His sword, a Weapon of Destiny known as The Blade of the Unlikely Champion, didn't care to be away from Albert for very long. It had a habit of falling over and breaking things when that happened, no matter how securely it was stored. And while he'd never actually admitted it to any of us, we all suspected that Albert felt the same about it. The two were joined at a level that not even brilliant mages like Amy truly understood.

"Hey, Fred," he called, shutting the door behind him.

"Albert, good to see you. Come on over." I was waiting for him, sitting at my desk, prepared for the conversation about to take place. It wouldn't be an easy one, and in truth, I'd have preferred to avoid it, but this needed to happen. Roderick was right about one thing: whether I liked it or not, I was the head of a clan now. That meant it was my responsibility to look out for the people in it.

"Are the documents not ready?" Albert asked, clearly confused by the empty surface of my desk.

"There are no documents for delivery tonight, Albert. I called you here because I wanted to have a talk with you, friend to friend, and employer to employee." Gently, I motioned to the empty chair in front of my desk.

Albert eyed it suspiciously, but took the seat nonetheless, setting his bag down on the floor. "I . . . did I do something wrong, Fred?"

"Not at all. You have been a model employee from the first day you came here, Albert. True, mistakes occurred, but you've always tried your best and made sure to learn from them. You are pleasant, and dedicated, and a fine young man. I would be proud and happy to keep you in my employ forever." My words halted, unintentionally. Right now, I could still call this off. Pretend it was a performance review, and that I was giving him a raise. But it wouldn't be right. Sure, it would make Albert happy for the evening, maybe for a whole week. Eventually though, the issue would rise again. It was time to start looking at the long-term.

"Yet I have to ask myself, is that what would make *you* happy, Albert? I saw the look in your eyes at Neil's party. Neil's *birthday* party. The one marking his age increasing, him physically growing older. You and I are rising in years; however, we aren't really aging, not anymore. That bothers you, doesn't it?"

For a long moment, the room was silent, and I thought Albert would clam up rather than address the issue. Finally, he tilted his head forward in a slight nod. "This one wasn't so bad. It just got me thinking. Ten years from now, twenty, fifty. Neil's going to keep getting older. He's going to turn into a man. And I'll always be stuck as a sixteen-year-old kid. I guess . . . part of me started feeling scared that I was going to get left behind."

"I understand. It's something I've grappled with myself. I imagine all

undead have to find a way to make peace with the dilemma,” I told him. “But before we go any further, allow me to say one thing: of all the fears and concerns we might have in our lives, Neil leaving you behind shouldn’t be one of them. The friendship you two share is remarkable, and I’d say he’s at least as joined to you as that sword, if not more so.”

The distinct sound of metal rattling echoed from within his duffel bag, and we both pointedly ignored it. “However,” I continued, “as far as the fear about having stopped growing, you’re right to be worried. We don’t age anymore, so I think it’s easy for our kind to become stagnant. Perhaps that’s what happens to people like Petre and Quinn. They reach a certain point and then simply halt, ignoring the changing world around them, or willfully shutting it out to maintain their status quo. People like you and I will not change naturally, Albert. Which means it’s all the more important that we take it upon ourselves to keep growing in the non-physical ways.”

“I kind of get your meaning, but I don’t totally understand what you’re saying.” There wasn’t an iota of shame in Albert’s voice. Of all the great and important beings I’d met, Albert was the humblest of the lot, never hesitant to admit to his failings or need to improve. In many ways, I respected that far more than Richard’s strength, or Gideon’s raw power.

“What I’m getting at is that perhaps it’s time to move on from this job.” It pained me to say those words, just as I could see it hurt Albert to hear them. But pain was an aspect of growing; it came part and parcel with the process. “When I took you in, you lacked any other options. That’s no longer the case. With that blade and Neil’s elevated station, there are several new possibilities in front of you. Maybe you don’t want any of them, and are holding out for something that suits you better. If that’s the case, then I’ll let the issue drop here and now. However, it struck me that you might be staying on as my assistant because it’s comfortable, and those new options are as scary as they are intriguing. Should that be the case, then I’d be doing you a disservice by not urging you to consider moving on. It would be a failure as your boss, and your friend.”

Another rattle rose from the duffel bag, this one more subdued. I had no idea what to make of that, but seeing as I wasn’t the one bonded to the blade, that was okay. All that mattered was that it meant something to Albert, and as an expression of uncertainty danced across his face, I had a feeling that it did.

“Do you need an answer right now? I’d like to think about this for a while, if that’s okay,” Albert replied.

“Take all the time you want, Albert. This isn’t a firing. This is just me making sure you’re on the path you want to be on. If the answer is yes, then so be it. If the answer is no, then know that you will be missed, but I would much rather see you growing in a direction that makes you happy. However, if



you decide to stay on for now, you will need to continue in your position for at least a week.”

“Why a week?” Albert looked up at me, his inner turmoil momentarily displaced by the bright flash of curiosity that only he could wear so nakedly.

“The Agency has requested that Fletcher Accounting Services conduct a cataloging and value assessment for the contents of a recently cleared out property,” I explained. “It was apparently home to a nest of . . . something. They’re sparse on the details in that regard. Anyway, I’ll need to bring both you and Lillian along, given the scope of the job. Neil as well, if he’s willing, since the report indicates there might be magical items to sort through. We leave in two days, so once we’re at the location, you won’t be able to come back until the work is done. Thus, you’d have to stay on for roughly a week, based on how long I expect the job to take.”

“I can do that. I think a week is good. It gives me time to think things over, anyway.” Standing up, Albert reached down and scooped up his duffel bag, effortlessly tossing it over one shoulder. “Do you need me to do anything else tonight, Fred?”

“No, you’re free to spend the evening as you wish. Just have a bag packed before it’s time to depart. I’ll meet you both at Charlotte Manor, and we’ll go from there.”

“Can do.” Albert walked back over to the front door and put his hand on the knob. “Fred . . . thanks. I get that it probably wasn’t easy to tell me all that, and hearing it sort of hurt to, but I think I needed it. Thank you for caring enough to say it. No matter what I choose, you should know that you’ve been the best boss anyone could ask for, zombie or human.”

He bolted through the door before I could respond, not even bothering to lock it behind him. Rising from my desk, I made my way over and turned the deadbolts back into place, then walked to the wine rack and pulled off a Pinot Noir I’d purchased for a special occasion or an especially rough day.

Pouring a tall glass, I sniffed it briefly before taking a long drink. Albert hadn’t been wrong about the difficulty of the discussion, and even now that it was done, my head was filled with worrying voices, all whispering to me about whether or not I’d actually done the right thing. I took another long gulp, trying to quiet them down. There wouldn’t be a way to know if I’d made the right call, not until Albert and I were much further down the line. All I could do was trust that my intentions and concern had come through well, and try very hard not to dwell on all the ways this could go wrong.

Leadership was proving to be even harder than I expected.

## **An Assessment at the Castle**

1.

A realtor, motivated as much by thoughts of commission as the desire to never visit such a place again, would have called the property rustic. Spacious and rustic, with good bones, that was just aching for someone with a can-do spirit to give it the spit and polish needed to restore its former glory. All of which would have been a very cordial method of saying this place was a hellhole that served as a living testament to how lax the community's building codes were.

But, all of that said, it was still a castle, and as a man who'd grown up in a small town, only to move to an urban environment, there was something fundamentally awe-inspiring about looking up at a real life castle. Behind me, Albert and Neil stepped out of the van, both reeling back in wonder at the massive stone estate sitting—crumbling, really—before us. Only Lillian seemed unaffected by the sight, slipping out of her seat and strolling over with a briefcase in one hand, a duffel bag full of equipment in the other.

“Guys, come on. You look like this is your first castle.”

“It is,” Albert told her.

“Oh. Well, it's kind of a shitty one, heads up. Dial back the stares, act like you've been there.” She strolled past us, not bothering to wait as we finally stopped gaping and got ourselves into gear.

Fenmoore Estates, the proper name for the castle and grounds we were visiting, was the site of what my documentation had referred to as an “attempted planar breaching” that had been quelled by the Agency. Neither Krystal nor Arch had been particularly forthcoming with what exactly that meant, only that it had probably been a pain to deal with and required quite a bit of cleanup. Since it seemed all those with claim to the estate were either deceased or under arrest for, and again I'll quote the document, “crimes against the commonly agreed upon reality,” the estate and everything within had become government property. Obviously, this would have been a more cumbersome process under normal law; however, parahumans had many aspects streamlined in their treaties, and not all were crafted to their benefit.

As a freelance accountant, it was my job to inventory the assets, look through any financial information I could find, and present it all to the Agency with a nice little bow. They'd have their own specialists determine the value of antiques and artifacts; all we had to deal with was sorting and combing through fiscal records, if any existed. Truth be told, that last part seemed like a hell of a longshot. Parahumans in general avoided keeping fastidious records, if they kept any at all, and this certainly didn't seem like the home of someone who was adapting with the times. Still, it was an assignment, and my first one for the Agency, so I was set on ensuring we did

a good job.

We made our way across the drawbridge, which would have been more intimidating if it had been over an actual moat instead of a muddy ditch with a trickle of water running through it, and Lillian easily yanked open one of the heavy wooden doors despite the burden in her hands. As a more . . . classically trained vampire, Lillian had actually needed the brute strength that came with being a blood-enthusiast, and she wasn't shy about using it. I'd never inquired as to what sort of blood she'd been drinking when we met, as it seemed like too personal a question to broach, but so far as I was aware, she'd been buying her nourishment through the same Agency-approved source I did since joining the House of Fred, so at least I knew she wasn't breaking any laws.

As we followed her in, I took note of the doors, thick wooden slabs that they were. On the outside were an array of etched symbols, sprawling lines that actually made a rather becoming pattern. The inside, however, was a different story. I couldn't tell if similar symbols had been scrawled in because the door was almost completely covered in scratch marks—no . . . claw marks. Whatever had been in here had wanted out, bad. Scary as the Agency could be to most parahumans, I nearly shuddered at the idea of what might have gotten loose had they not been around to deal with this issue.

Once past the doors, our eyes were drawn to the wreckage of the entranceway. It might have been beautiful before, but all we could see now were gunshot holes, broken marble floors, and entire sections of wall that had been knocked in. Evidently, this fight hadn't been an easy one, or the owner had really let the place go to hell before the incident occurred. Either way, all that remained was but a ghost of the grandeur this place had once possessed.

Movement came from further down the entrance hall, and all of us froze. Well, all of us save for Albert, who was still staring up at the ceiling with his mouth open. Thankfully, it didn't turn out to be an issue, as I quickly recognized the inhuman beauty and grace of the person stepping into view.

"June? Is that you?"

She glanced up from the papers in her hand, easily sidestepping a pile of debris despite the fact that she should have had no way of noticing it, and grinned at us. "Hey, Fred. Didn't realize you were the one taking custody of this place. Short time, no see."

I started over toward her, only to quickly realize that no one else was following. One look over my shoulder showed that Albert and Neil were both staring with far more reverence than they'd shown for the castle, and Lillian, much to my surprise, harbored an expression that was nearly as awestruck. I've mentioned before how lovely June and September—and presumably all those with fey-blood—are, but I thought my fellow vampire would have been a little more composed than the two teens.

“Fredrick,” Lillian whispered through clenched teeth. “Is that a . . . fey?”

“Half-fey, actually.” June pulled up her hair to reveal ears that ended in a very visible point. “And these puppies aren’t just for show. Don’t worry, though; the stories about us are worse than the reality. Usually, anyway. Plus, you’re here as friends, so it’s all good.”

“Is there something I’m missing?” I asked, giving up on the rest of the group and walking over to June.

“I’d guess it’s half wonder and half terror,” June replied, apparently unbothered by the staring. “There aren’t a whole lot of people with significant fey blood, so seeing us is something of a rarity, and then there’s the fact that fey-blooded Agents are often used to handle troublesome vampires. We’re on par with most of you physically, and you all can’t just drink our blood from the tap. Fey blood has to be specially treated by a skilled alchemist before vampires can ingest it; otherwise, there are some . . . adverse reactions.”

“You’re . . . lovely.” It was the first thing Albert had said since we got out of the van, and while he wasn’t wrong, it was also hardly an appropriate thing to say in the midst of a job. June, thankfully, merely responded with a quick smile and a wave.

“Thanks so much. It’s just good skincare and healthy eating.” She chuckled to herself, and then turned back to me, business-face back in the position. “Don’t worry about them; they’ll be fine after I leave. We tend to cast a bit of an aura of wonderment by nature, and it gets stronger in places where we’ve thrown around a lot of juice. Which I *definitely* did in here. This was a tough fight. September and I were against the wall a few times, but we came out okay in the end. I just finished the last sweep, and while there is a ton of lingering magic in the air, I can officially say there are no more . . . the nest is gone and the infestation is wiped out.”

Her eyes had darted over to the others at the last second, clearly remembering that she was talking to freelancing civilians rather than fellow agents. She thrust the stack of pages over to me, a pen resting on top. “Anyway, here’s the turnover forms. Give me a few signatures saying I waited and did the hand-off properly so I can get out of here. There’s a library down the left hall that’s more or less still in one piece. I’d recommend using that as a base of operations. A lot of the rooms are less stable, and as a bonus, the library doesn’t have any windows. No pesky sunlight to worry about.”

“I appreciate the suggestion. Lillian, Albert, Neil, would you all mind taking the equipment to the library while I finish up with Agent Windbrook?”

None of them moved with much enthusiasm, and I noticed that Lillian gave June a wide berth, but slowly they left the entrance area as I worked my way through the paperwork. Bothersome as I’m sure some found the pages, it was actually a rather reassuring process for me. Paperwork felt

familiar, like the situation was well under control and everything was neatly handled. That feeling alone probably should have tipped me off that there would be trouble, but I am nothing if not a dedicated optimist, so I put the final signature onto the documents without so much as a twinge of dread and handed them back to June.

“The handover is done, and you are free to go, Agent Windbrook.”

“Glad as I am to hear that, let’s stick with June, at least when the lackeys aren’t around,” she said, flipping through the pages to make sure I hadn’t missed anything. “I appreciate that you’re trying to be professional while on the clock, but you’re my best friend’s beau, and neither Krys nor I are big on formality. May as well keep things friendly.”

“You raise a good point,” I agreed.

“And on the note of friendship, make sure you and your people don’t poke around here too much,” June added. “September and I handled the main threat, but like I said before, there is a lot of lingering magic. It’s been deemed clear for Agency workers, not the general public. Do your work and all, but if you walk into a room and every instinct you have screams that you should run, then run. In my experience, vampires usually have pretty solid survival instincts.”

It was sound advice, although perhaps giving it to me while I stood in the rubble of the entrance hall wasn’t the most useful of locations to support it, but I still nodded my head. “We’ll keep that in mind, thank you.”

“No problem.” She folded the papers up, made a flourish with her hand, and suddenly, they were gone. “One last thing. The sword strapped to that zombie’s back—am I losing my mind, or was that The Blade of the Unlikely Champion?” I’d nearly forgotten that June had grabbed onto the same sword, still in the sheath, when she almost fell from the catwalk at CalcuCon.

“It is indeed. Turns out my assistant was the new wielder it wanted.”

“Small, strange world.” June chuckled again, a sound like bells being rung atop summer hilltops. “You all be careful. Oh, and tell Krys I’ve got some vacation saved up and I’ll be visiting soon. Still hammering out details, but I’ll let her know when I’ve got the dates set.”

“I know she’ll look forward to it,” I replied.

I watched as June made her way out the door, opening the heavy wooden slab with as much ease as Lillian, if not more. Only when it was shutting did I realize I’d wanted to ask about the scratches on the inside, but I made no move to stop her. She probably wouldn’t have been able to tell me, anyway. After all, I was just here to do inventory.

2.

Despite what movies had conditioned me to expect after an ominous warning in a creepy area, there was no sudden appearance of a supernatural entity or unseen terror that descended upon us. In fact, the work went rather smoothly for some time. Neil and Albert were our exploratory team, checking the nearby areas for anything of measurable value, which turned up surprisingly few items. Granted, the furniture would have certainly been considered antiques if it hadn't all been smashed or chopped into splinters. But whatever had gone on here, precious few areas were spared, and as a result, they more often returned with a few dented candlesticks or simple rings than anything truly valuable.

Lillian and I, on the other hand, were dealing with the library itself. While I trusted that Albert would be able to spot any financial ledgers during his scouting work, I also knew enough about parahumans to assume that some might toss their monetary records in with the rest of their books. After all, pages were pages—at least to some folks. Besides that, a generous amount of tomes had managed to survive whatever battle had been waged inside these walls, and many appeared old enough to have considerable worth. Since it was the only real treasure trove we'd yet located, inventorying and storing the books seemed like a good place to start. And while the subject matter varied greatly, we did start to notice a very clear trend as the first night's efforts were drawing to a close.

"*More Lovecraft*," Lillian announced, plopping several books down into a pile. "How many first editions does one person need, anyway?"

"To be fair, we don't know how many people were using this space," I reminded her. "Maybe several people with the same passion shared this as a common area."

"Uh huh. Or we've got one person who went looney and started hoarding books."

Even as I took the next book from the top of the pile to log into our records, I fought hard to suppress a grin. Lillian was, for the most part, a cosmopolitan vampire who was well-adapted to modern times. Every now and then, however, her language use would slip and reveal her age. Given that she'd been around since somewhere in the 1800s, a few archaic terms were bound to worm their way into her vernacular—words like "looney," which I was reasonably sure I'd only ever heard Arch use without referencing children's cartoons.

"Also, I have a few more for the Neil pile." If Lillian noticed my amusement, she didn't show it. Instead, she dropped two more tomes onto the small stack we were holding for Neil to look over. While only a Journeyman in his mage training, he was still by far the most educated among us in terms

of magic. As soon as we flagged a book as relating to the arcane, it was put away for him to evaluate. Much as we wanted to catalog everything properly, this was as much about safety as it was accuracy. Magic was dangerous stuff; even books about it were best left in the hands of those who knew what they were doing.

“So, what do you think went down in this place, anyway?” Lillian had paused after unloading her latest armful of books and was staring around the massive library with a wistful expression.

“You’ve seen much more of the parahuman world than I have. It seems like you’d be able to make a better educated guess,” I pointed out.

“Yeah, you say that, but I’ve never been on a first-name basis with a half-fey. Or a dragon, for that matter. But I guess neither of those are likely suspects, anyway.” Lillian walked along the stone floor, her feet making a distinct click with every motion. From our vantage point, we could see out into the hallway, where several broken walls gave us views of decimated rooms. “Not ghouls, for starters. They nest, but I can’t imagine why dealing with them would leave lingering magic. The agents probably would have just set this whole place on fire and shot any that escaped. Obviously, vampires are out; most of us have too much taste to live somewhere so . . . stereotypical. Besides, I’d smell it if that much blood had been spilt.”

Lillian paused her walk and looked over at me, her expression suddenly surprised. “Hang on . . . Fredrick, do you smell *any* blood?”

I paused my book-gathering, tilting my head up and taking a deep sniff. Although I usually worked hard to keep from focusing on my senses too much, no amount of selective attention could block the electric thrill that raced through my brain at the barest sniff of blood. We were hardwired for it; it was our sustenance. No such jolt hit me as I inhaled, however. Just a lot of lingering sweat, gunpowder, and the overwhelming smell of books. “None that I can detect.”

“Me either. Which is weird, don’t you think? This place has been ripped apart. It looks like a tornado tore through the interior, but we can’t pick up a single drop of blood? I’ll give you that it’s hard to make a fey bleed, so maybe the agents didn’t shed any. But none of the things they were fighting? That’s hard for me to swallow.”

“It was probably scrubbed when the corpses were cleared out,” I told her. “I assume the Agency is quite good at handling cleanup.”

“Maybe.” Lillian looked out into the hallway for a few seconds longer, taking several more deep sniffs. “But they’d need some powerful cleaners to keep it from us. Alchemic grade. I guess it could have been something they did as a nicety, since they knew two vampires were coming. Or maybe, and this feels a lot more likely, whatever they were fighting in here didn’t have any blood.”



“No blood?” My forehead grew creased as I scoured my brain, searching my memory for the various parahumans I’d met. With the exception of Charlotte, all of them had been creatures capable of bleeding. Even partly dead ones like Albert and myself. “What sorts of parahumans don’t have blood?”

“Very few types, and almost none of them good.” Lillian turned from the entrance and headed toward the bookshelf she’d been working her way through. “Also, the boys are on their way back. I caught their scent getting stronger. Should only be a few minutes.”

Sure enough, less than five minutes later Albert and Neil entered the library. Between them, they’d collected only a few items, most of which would almost certainly be classified as junk. One piece in particular stood out as bad: a half-burned black candle that Neil had put into a plastic baggie.

“Candle, huh?” Lillian looked over my shoulder as Neil set it carefully onto the floor, well away from anything else. “You worried the power might fail, and we didn’t bring enough flashlights?”

“I know how it looks, but this isn’t for cataloguing. I just didn’t think it was safe to leave it lying around,” Neil explained. “Someone used this as a magical implement, probably in a ceremony, and it’s still giving off a glow like its active. Amy always says abandoned implements are like forgotten land mines, so I’m going to do a quick sealing ceremony on it.”

Sometimes, especially in the more recent year, it was hard to look at Neil and remember the power hungry mage who’d tried to sacrifice a crowd of his fellow LARPers (as well as me and Krystal) to gain a bump in power. Amy’s influence was evident, but some credit also went to time and maturity. Neil had begun to realize the scope of what he was messing with, how powerful magic truly was, and he’d taken the responsibility seriously.

“We found it right by a basement door, so we’re going to check that out next,” Albert added. “Neil just wanted to take care of his candle and put some wards on us first.”

“Wards?” I set my pen down, staring at Neil. “You know I’m never against being prudent, but why the sudden increase in defenses?”

Neil had produced a piece of chalk from the pockets of his robe and was just finishing up enclosing the candle in a circle as I asked my question. “Nothing I can put a finger on, precisely. It was a vibe I got when we went near the door, like all the magic lingering around was a little more potent there. It’s probably no big deal, maybe the site of a ceremony or something, but I figured it wouldn’t kill me to spend ten minutes on warding us before we went down.”

June’s warning pinged through my mind, her explicit instructions to run if it felt like running was what I should do. The advice seemed a touch redundant, as I’d never been shy about putting my feet into motion when

danger was near. However, Neil hadn't said the room felt particularly dangerous, only powerful, and with so much residual magic in the building as a whole, we probably wouldn't be able to skip every room where it was a little stronger. This was our first job for the Agency; we needed to be thorough and prove we were up to the task. Half-assing it because some rooms gave us the willies wouldn't fly as an excuse. Even knowing all of that though, I couldn't ask them to go into the unknown on their own. June had said vampires had good instincts, so I needed to see what mine told me.

"Neil, if you don't mind, can you ward me as well? I'm going to tag along with you both to check out this basement. And if I say we need to turn back once we're in there, I expect both of you to listen and obey. We're still in dangerous terrain, and our safety is the most important part of any job."

Putting the chalk back into his pocket, Neil pulled out a small golden watch and checked the time. "We'll have to hurry. There are a lot of places between here and there with windows, and it's going to take longer to put wards on you than on Albert and me, so we'll be racing the sunrise."

"It's a risk, but we'll just have to be careful as we make our way over," I told him. "Even once it starts to come up, I'm sure there are plenty of shadowy areas I can maneuver through."

"Worse comes to worse, you could always bust through a few walls," Lillian suggested. Evidently my expression must have conveyed how shocked I was at the idea, because she shrugged her shoulders and responded. "What? It's not like anyone is going to notice a little more damage in this place."

"If neither of you minds, I would greatly like to concentrate on my current task so I can get us prepared to head back out." A little of Neil's usual grouchiness had slipped back into his tone, which had been polite around Lillian. He reached into the same pocket he'd drawn the chalk from, but this time pulled out a familiar book that in no way should have fit in such a small space. It was the tome of magic he'd found in his grandparent's attic, the one that had started him on his magical journey to revive a best friend who had passed away: namely, Albert. Clearly it had other uses, too, as he sat down next to his chalk circle and began to read from the pages.

Something in the air seemed to ripple near the candle, and for a moment, I was sure I felt a cold breath run across the back of my neck. I quickly convinced myself that it was either my imagination or a side effect of the spell Neil was casting. Whether it was true or not was irrelevant at that point; I couldn't head out to a spooky magical basement with those sorts of thoughts in my head.

3.

In my time working with parahumans, I'd seen much scarier things than the basement door. Gideon stood out as the frontrunner, aided in no small part by the menacing aura he projected naturally; although, even after I'd gained immunity to that, he'd still terrified me, because I'd gotten a glimpse of just how strong he really was. There were also plenty of other things I'd had genuine cause to be afraid of: the therians who'd kidnapped me, my sire and his assault on my home, the mad vampire hunter who'd shot me with a harpoon . . . I could go on for some time. Which, now that I write that, is a somewhat horrifying statement in and of itself.

However, while I'd seen plenty that actually scared me, few things up to that point had ever been so . . . creepy. Forgive the stale description, but it's hard to find accurate words for the sense that filled me as I stared at the dense wooden door, made from the same material as those in the front of the castle. I wasn't afraid; none of my primal vampire senses were saying I was in danger. All the same, something just felt off. Wrong. Like I was near something not meant to be. Which, given that I had an office in a magically animated house, meant that it had to be pretty far along the weird spectrum.

"Not that I don't love standing here watching you stare at a door, but we might want to get somewhere a little less bright soon." Neil pointed behind us, to where a surprisingly intact window was being slowly filled with the sun's rays. Our position was currently protected by the shadows, but sooner or later, the hall would inevitably become inhospitable to me.

In retrospect, perhaps deciding to explore the basement just before the sun would make escaping it highly dangerous had been a poor decision. Then again, it wasn't like I'd known the exact layout we'd be dealing with before I'd thrown out the idea. None of that mattered, though; I was there, and having seen how many windows and holes in the wall dotted our journey back, leaving would be nearly as risky as staying.

"I suppose we should head on in." I walked forward, taking the metal handle (which felt colder than it rightly should have) in my grip. Before I pulled it open, I turned briefly back to Albert and Neil. "Listen up. Even if I can't leave, if I say you need to run, then do as I say."

"We won't leave you behind, Fred," Albert told me. Neil looked less sold on the sentiment, but he kept the opinion to himself.

"Yes, you will. I'm your boss, and I'll be giving you an order which I expect you to obey. And you don't need to worry. Vampires are a tough lot. We can withstand quite a bit. My larger concern is for Neil. As the only one of us completely alive, he's the most vulnerable, and I'll expect you to watch over him as he escapes, Albert."

My assistant didn't have a counter ready for that, and even Neil

seemed a bit taken aback by my concern. I didn't wait for either of them to rekindle the argument. Instead, I pulled open the door to the basement and revealed a flight of stone stairs. "At least they stuck with the décor."

Unlike the rest of the castle, which had at least hosted a few working bulbs in every room we'd seen so far, this area was pitch black within the first few steps. Of course, that was no issue for me or Albert, and I heard Neil mumble some seemingly gibberish words from behind us before advancing. Since he made it down several steps without tripping over his robes and tumbling into us, it seemed a fair wager that he'd just cast a spell to see in the darkness.

After staring at the door, meditating on the sense of creepiness that came off of it, what lay before us was somewhat anti-climactic: just stone walls and floor, a few more bullet scars and scratches along the ground to mark the battle that had taken place, and a pair of doors at opposite ends of the room. In other words, exactly what one would expect to find in the basement of a castle where something wicked had been recently wiped out. We made it to the end of the stairs without anything leaping out at us or striking from the shadows, and did a quick sweep of the area. No one found anything we hadn't seen when walking in, which made it all the stranger that the creepy vibe wasn't dispersing. If anything, it was getting stronger.

"What now?" Albert asked. It didn't escape my notice that even though we'd yet to encounter a single tangible threat, his hand was still perpetually near the hilt of his sword. I wasn't sure if Albert knew he was doing it, or if such habits were just part of wielding magical weapons. Even more worrying, I wondered briefly if the sword itself was piloting the gesture, a thought I chose not to cling to, as it raised a myriad of potential questions and this was not the time to linger.

"We've come all the way down here, and our way back will be difficult for me to get through until sunset, so I'd say our best option is to go ahead and fully explore the area," I told him. "Obviously, we're going to stay together, but it looks like these doors lead to small tunnels. Best case: perhaps we find a way back to the library. Worst case: we can at least take a full inventory and catalog this area while you two run whatever we find back to Lillian." Admittedly, that was something of an optimistic worst case scenario; however, I didn't see the need to worry Albert any more than was necessary.

"Fred's right. We're here, so let's work." Surprised as I was to hear Neil agree with me, it struck me as interesting that his whole body was tenser than usual. Whatever strange vibes this area was putting off, I clearly wasn't the only one feeling them.

We made our way through the nearest doorway, at what I was guessing to be the south of the room, and down the hall. For the most part, it was more of the same: chips in the rock where bullets had hit next to claw

marks. Idly, I wondered just how many bullets September and June had fired during their battle. Neither had particularly struck me as the gun-toting type, yet it seemed like they'd emptied an armory's worth of ammunition into this castle. Maybe whatever they'd been fighting was particularly susceptible to bullets, although that could be said of pretty much all creatures, assuming the bullets were made of the right material. Strangely though, I realized there were no flecks of metal or casings. Had they all been cleaned up? Just like the blood, it seemed as though even the most thorough of scrubblings should have left at least a few telltale signs behind.

After checking out a small broom closet (literally, it was filled with nothing but old brooms), and a room stacked nearly to the rafters with cans of creamed corn, we eventually made our way to a doorway that was blatantly out of place. It was metal, new, and had everything save for a neon sign with the words "Does Not Belong" on it. Albert's hand crept a little closer to the hilt of his blade, and Neil reached into his pocket to pull out a few vials filled with strangely colored substances. Given who his teacher was, there was no way on earth to predict exactly what those potions might do, so I waved him back a few feet.

Upon closer inspection, I noticed that while the door was very out of place, it did have one thing in common with the rest of the house: it was damaged. The locks on the edge had been violently sundered or ripped clean out. This wasn't some area that June had missed; it was just one more cleared out room where she'd happened to leave the door closed. I relaxed, slightly, and motioned for the others to come closer. As I was moving my hand, I leaned in a little closer and caught a strange whiff in my nose. Not of blood, or gunpowder, or any of the things I'd been searching for. No, this was something that ticked off a very different reaction in my vampire mind, one of instant fear and recoiling.

Silver. Clearly not the whole door—it was much too sturdy for that—but woven through the structure like veins. It made a certain amount of sense; not many parahumans could even be near the stuff, let alone touch it, so having a door with silver added in was a smart way to keep out those strong enough to rip through steel. Too bad for whomever had built this place: the fey were among the few who were unaffected by such materials. If someone had wanted to keep the Windbrooks out, they should have used iron.

"Albert, hang back for a moment. This door has silver in it." Zombies were among the many who were weakened by silver, though not to the same extent as vampires. I never completely understood how it worked, but from what I could put together, the more magic a parahuman had, the more susceptible they were to the effects of silver. Up to a point, anyway. Dragons had more magic in them than nearly any other kind of creature I'd encountered, and apparently they were barely bothered by the stuff. Whether

they were immune by nature or just too powerful to be affected was up for debate; magic, like life, rarely came with explicit rules and instructions.

Thankfully, of the three of us, I at least didn't have to worry about the silver issue. Taking a firm grip on the door, I yanked it forward to reveal the room inside. Unfortunately, I didn't get the chance to take in the sights before something bolted right into me. No, right *through* me. It burst past the door I'd opened, flinging itself into the hall and hovering a few feet between me and Neil.

"Trespassers!" The voice was odd: booming and deep, yet more like an echo than something that had come from so close. Now that the figure had stopped moving, I could see that it was male—a lanky fellow with wild hair, crazed eyes, and a patchwork ensemble that might have made sense when it had distinct colors, but that sort of all blended together in the indistinct, foggy form that composed this person.

"Well, hot damn," Neil said, seeming far more at ease than he was when we were all creeping through the halls. "My first ghost. Amy isn't going to believe this."

4.

While Neil was taking the revelation in stride, the rest of us were momentarily dumbfounded. And I do mean *all* of us. Albert and I were both staring up at the semi-transparent figure in shock, while he was glaring down at Neil with a very clear expression of disbelief.

“You can see me? But I’ve not marshalled my energies together enough to appear to mortal eyes.”

“Ghosts have to work to be noticed by most people.” Neil looked to Albert and me as he explained. “Human senses aren’t built to pick up the spectrum where they naturally exist.”

Our floating new acquaintance jerked his head around, taking note of the people besides Neil. “And you two as well? How is this possible?”

“Taking a wild guess here, maybe I can see you because I’m a vampire?” I tossed out.

Albert jabbed his thumb into his chest. “Zombie.”

“They can both see you because they’ve stepped partway across the threshold between life and death,” Neil said, taking a step closer and examining the ghost. “Whereas I am a mage who specializes in the magic revolving around the power of death: a necromancer. Learning to see through the veil is one of the first tricks we learn.”

“A sorcerer of corpses. How pointless.” The ghost sneered, floating further away from Neil. “I suppose I must thank you, trespassers, for setting me free. When I built that room, it was to keep prying snoopers out. I hadn’t calculated the possibility of being trapped in there myself. As reward for your aid, I shall ensure that the wave that washes over the world will devour you all quickly, without making you endure needless suffering.”

I couldn’t speak for the others, but that sort of declaration left me with more than a few questions, none of which I got to ask. Kicking off the empty air, the ghost bolted upward, vanishing through the ceiling over our heads.

“Should we be worried about that?” Albert asked.

“Possibly, though it’s not likely. Based on his density and composition, the man is a recently formed ghost. That means he’s not going to have enough strength to do more than maybe knock a book off a shelf or slam a door. And since the only other person in here is Lillian, it’s not like he’ll be able to get a drop on her,” Neil said.

I was still looking at the ceiling where he’d vanished, trying to mentally map what I knew about the castle and predict where he’d risen up at. “And if he leaves the estate?”

Neil shook his head. “No way. Some spirits—really powerful ones with a lot of experience and mojo—can sever themselves from their point of

departure, but most are, far and away, anchored to the place where they died. My money says he won't even be able to get past the moat, and even if he does, there's nothing nearby for miles."

"Hey. Um, Fred, Neil . . . I think you should look at this." Albert had stuck his head through the open doorway and was peeking into the room where the ghost had been hiding. He walked forward, making room for Neil and I to follow, which we did.

Silence descended as we took in what had been tucked away from view by the slab of metal. It was a lab—I'd seen Amy's often enough to recognize that much—or at least it was the wrecked remains of one. Broken glass littered the floor in all directions, partially burned tables were flipped over, and shredded pages decorated the ground indiscriminately. More stunning by far, though, were the machines. Great metallic pieces that had been sundered into bits, it was like finding the bones of a massive mechanical beast. Even though it no longer posed a threat, the mere reminders of what had once been were enough to put my nerves on edge. Without thinking, I took a sniff of the air and, finally, it hit me.

Blood. Not a lot, and severely reduced by the cleaning products that had been run over it, but it was a smell I would never mistake for anything else. I followed the trail toward the back of the room, where I found a cluster of bullet marks in the wall and a few dark smears: all that remained of whoever had been brought down here. As I examined the chips in the rock the bullets had left behind, I caught a small glimmer near the edge of one hole. Leaning closer, I took a test whiff to confirm. Sure enough: there was silver woven into the walls of this room as well. Probably the ceiling and floor, too. While that did explain why the ghost hadn't simply exited through one of the walls the way he did in the basement, it only raised more questions as to what exactly had been going on in this place.

"Found a television!" From across the room, Albert was hauling up an antique TV from the ground. It had a crack down the center of the screen, but was otherwise surprisingly intact—at least compared to the wreckage that decorated the rest of the room. "It probably needs some repairs, but maybe it's worth money, since it's an antique? If it's just the screen, that's a small fix."

Before I could protest, Albert began to fiddle with the knobs on the front of the set. To my surprise, the cracked screen flickered to life, a green glow radiating through the dark room. The picture was distorted, warped, like tuning in to a premium channel that one hadn't purchased. But as Albert adjusted the knobs, it began to change. Some of the static vanished, and blobs of shadow amidst the green glow began to take on actual shapes. Not the shapes of anything remotely familiar, mind you, just shapes that were slightly more stable than before.

I inched my way over without meaning to, craning my neck to get a



better view, and nearly bumped into Neil, who was doing the same thing. As my eyes left the screen for a brief moment, I noticed a detail that I'd missed previously: there were no cords running to the TV. Admittedly, battery technology had been around for a long while, but I had a pretty solid hunch that that wasn't what we were dealing with.

"Albert, perhaps you should set that down," I suggested.

"Come on, Fred, aren't you a little curious about what we're seeing?" Neil asked. "And it's not like the agents would have left anything behind if it was dangerous."

That didn't ring entirely true—June herself had cautioned me that places like this came with some inherent risk—but before I could say so, Albert made a twist of one of the top knobs and the picture snapped into clear view. I stared at the jumble of images, trying to make sense of what I was seeing. Limbs pawed at the glass, so numerous it was hard to make out how many belonged to each being. Some were like tentacles; others had sharp, single-bladed claws; a few were adorned with eyes, ears, and a myriad of things that I have no point of reference from which to describe. These creatures, these *things*, they were utterly alien, no more like a human than I was like a giant squid. And there were so many of them. If not for the small sliver of sky visible at the top of the screen, it would have been easy to think they were all trapped inside the actual television set, trying to slice their way out.

The sky itself was a curiosity as well. While it, like everything else, was tinged by the green glow of the ancient screen, I could still make out three distinct moons hovering overhead. What in the hell were we watching? Some old sci-fi movie made with exceptional practical effects?

"Oh no." I turned to Neil, only to notice that much of the blood had drained from his face. "Oh, holy shit . . . oh shit, this is bad."

"What's wrong?" Albert was at his friend's side in a moment, leaving the television behind but the screen still on.

Neil's head jerked about, taking in the wreckage with new, panicked eyes. "Do either of you realize what happened here? That ghost we saw, he's the one who did all of this. He's a planomancer, a mage who specializes in manipulating and breaking through the dimensional boundaries between different planes of existence. All of this . . . it was caused by him bringing those things over."

I stared at the television with new perspective. Those clawed appendages—they did look like they could leave the right type of gashes on the stone floors, a solid match for countless slices we'd encountered. "But the agents took care of it. The nest is gone, all the big equipment is scrap, and the guy who was running things seems to have been . . . handled." I faltered a bit on that last word. It seemed pretty obvious that June and September had killed

that man, and looking at what he'd been trying to let through, I couldn't say I disagreed with that decision. Still, it was strange to imagine the ethereal man alive only a few days ago, brought down by a hail of gunfire from the same people I now worked for. "Besides, I thought the dead couldn't wield magic in the first place. That's what Amy once told me."

"That's the thing, though. A planomancer isn't the same kind of ghost as most people turn into. No wonder he knew we shouldn't have been able to see him, even as a newly made spirit. He knows ways to manipulate the veil between the ethereal world and ours, and that's assuming he didn't make any prep—fuck!" Neil slapped himself in the head so hard there was an audible *thump*. "The candle! That's why I could feel it humming with power—it was still in use. The thing was a magical bolt-bag. He probably left it behind as a just-in-case measure, in the event agents came through and busted up his little plan."

"But you sealed the candle," Albert pointed out.

"And if that's the only contingency he had, then we're fine, but color me skeptical at the idea that someone who builds an entire room encased in silver will only have a single backup tucked away." Neil spun around to face me. "Fred, we have to find that ghost. If he did leave some magical contingencies, there's a good chance he'll be able to cut his connection from the site of his death. And if that happens, then we've got a skilled mage who knows how to bring those things over and who can literally disappear the minute he's cornered." He pointed to the television, as if I'd forgotten what he might be referring to.

"The wave of darkness that washes over the world." I didn't plan on saying those words; they just bubbled up as I remembered the ghost's promise before vanishing. "That's what he meant. Those creatures are the wave he wants to bring over."

"Unless we stop him." Albert lifted the television set in one hand and hurled it to the ground, turning the device into more scrap upon the floor. It was a little dramatic, but it made the point well. We had to stop this ghost, or else next time we saw those things, it could very well be up close and personal.

5.

“I still say we call in some agents,” I protested.

“We can and should do that,” Neil agreed. “But it doesn’t change the fact that they won’t be here for at least a little while, and in that time, the ghost might get free.”

Our group had cleared out of the destroyed laboratory and back into the hallway, where there was room to move about without tripping on rubble. Neil was sitting on the ground, his necromancy tome open on his lap, while Albert stood guard nearby. For my part, I pulled out my phone to try and dial Krystal, who would hopefully be able to get a message to June. Sadly, the magic of horror movie tropes was with me this time, as I found myself completely without signal. Not a big surprise since we were in the middle of a basement beneath a massive castle sitting in the middle of nowhere, but still an extreme inconvenience. Rather than waste time, I typed out a text for Krystal and set my phone to continuously attempt to send every minute until the battery died or it went through. That small measure done, I tucked it back in my pocket and redirected my attention to Neil.

“If we’re the ones who have to deal with it, is there at least a plan to work with?”

“Sort of. Best I can come up with on the fly, anyway.” Neil had reached into his pockets once more and produced a pair of tea candles, the sort one would put inside a decorative sculpture on a dinner table. One more trip inside the pocket brought out a needle, which he began using to carve symbols into the soft white wax of the candle. “The candle I found gave me an idea. I’m going to try and make some guides to lead you both toward any big manifestations of magic. Even if the ghost can get to one, it will probably take some time for him to draw the energy out and wield it. We just need to grab all of the totems he might use, and then gather them in one place. When he comes to try and get them, I’ll be able to trap him.”

“And how do candles help us with this?” Albert asked, saving me the embarrassment of posing the query myself.

“With a few runes and a quick spell, I can make them into magic-detectors. I think I can, anyway. When Amy showed me how to do this, it looked a lot easier.” Neil finished etching symbols into the wax and set the needle down. Lifting the first candle up, he closed his eyes and whispered unintelligibly beneath his breath. Seconds later, the wax seemed to shift slightly, like the carvings had just grown deeper. That done, Neil pulled a lighter from his pocket and put a flame to the wick. It sputtered into existence, then leaned in the direction of further down the hallway, like someone was blowing on it, despite the fact that there wasn’t so much as a single draft of wind in the basement. Neil let out a whoop of triumph and handed the candle

off to Albert.

“It works! Just follow the direction of the flame like a compass, and it will lead you to nearest source of potent magic.”

I examined the item along with Albert, quite impressed at what Neil had managed to cobble together on the fly. Sometimes I forgot that he wasn’t growing solely in maturity, but was also being taught magic by one of the most revered mages in the whole state. “One problem jumps to mind: if this leads us to a magical object, won’t the flame just keep pointing at it once we pick it up? It would be like using a compass to hunt down a huge magnet.”

“Yes, Fred, that’s why I took out two,” Neil snapped as he worked on etching symbols into the second candle. “We split up, hunting our targets separately. As soon as you get yours, hightail it back to the library, since that’s where Albert and I will set up shop.”

“Hang on, why are you just assuming there will only be two of these things?” I asked, beating Albert to the punch for a change.

“Three.” Neil finished his etching work and dropped the needle into his pocket. “I found the first one already, so we just have to hunt down the other two. But it’s going to be three in total. That’s how these things work. It will either be three, and we can do this, or it’s seven or thirteen, in which case we’re screwed no matter what. So let’s just assume he stuck with the standard of three and get our butts in gear.”

As Neil lowered his head to cast a spell on the second candle, Albert looked from the flickering light to his friend, and then to me. It wasn’t hard to figure out what was on his mind. “Don’t worry, Albert. You’re going to be teamed up with Neil.”

“But you might need help, too,” he protested.

“We talked about this on the way in. I’m a vampire; he’s a human. Besides, the two of you have always been stronger together. You’re going with Neil, and that’s an order from your boss.” It took a lot of effort to sound confident as I told Albert how things were going to be, but based on the reassured look on his face, I felt like he’d bought it. The truth of the matter was that I did not like the idea of splitting up one bit, especially in unfamiliar terrain. That didn’t matter, though. If we were playing against a clock, then every second mattered. Besides, I’d probably be fine. I was a vampire, after all, and our kind surely weren’t that easy to kill.

The flick of a lighter broke the tension, as Neil created a flame on the second candle. It tilted in the same direction as the first, and Neil rose from his seat on the floor. “We’re going to have to get further away from whatever is down that hall if we want a new target. Albert, hand your candle to Fred. Since he’s not going to be able to explore the upstairs, he gets to tackle the basement. You and I will head back to the stairs.”

Gingerly, as though he were afraid it might burn us both, Albert set

the candle down in my hand. Once that was done, he reached up and adjusted the position of his sword to make sure it would draw easily. Aside from cleaning and training, he rarely ever pulled the blade from its sheath, but I knew he wouldn't hesitate if they found themselves in danger. I'd seen firsthand the depths of resolve Albert could summon when his best friend was in danger, and for the sake of the ghost, I hoped we found the magical objects before he found Albert and Neil. That sword had chopped a chimera back into its base creatures; I could only imagine what it would do to an insubstantial being.

"Be careful, Fred," Neil told me, stealing the words right out of my mouth. "We're going up against a mage on his home turf, and that's the most dangerous type of place to engage a magic-user, dead or not. Try to make it back to the library in one piece, or at least enough pieces that we can put you back together."

"Encouraging," I replied. "You two keep each other safe."

"We will." There was more force in Albert's words than usual, and his hand tightened on the hilt of his sword as he and Neil headed back down the hallway. It was hard to worry about them, honestly. Between Neil's expertise and Albert's raw power, I imagined there was precious little left in this house that could be a real threat to them.

When they were back to the stairs, I turned and started making my way further into the basement. The candle's direction was unwavering, but it was no substitute for a good map. More than once, it would be pointing directly into a wall, forcing me to work my way around the tunnels until I found a way past the obstacle and got back on track.

By the third detour, I had lost all sense of where I was and had begun to consider taking Lillian's advice by breaking down the next wall I encountered. Not my usual style, true, but time was of the essence, and I didn't imagine anyone would notice one more broken element in this castle. All that stayed my hand was the knowledge that any one of these might be load-bearing, and while I could be trapped under a sudden collapse, the ghost wouldn't be inconvenienced in the slightest. Mercifully, the way around was a short one, and as I rounded a bend, I found myself staring into a nearly empty room, directly where the candle was pointing.

I say nearly empty, because there were a few things in there: a busted bed frame with a stained mattress, a tattered stack of books next to a threadbare armchair, and a single glowing gem in the center of a cheap golden necklace. The gem probably didn't glow normally, or else whoever cleaned this place up certainly would have taken it into agency possession, but it was casting quite a bit of light now—dark, hunter green-colored light that was swirling up into the substantially less see-through form of our ghost.

He was hovering over it, hands outstretched as the swirling light

filled him, turning the misty form into something dark green and visible. I stepped in as the last of the glow faded from the gem and flowed up into the ghost. The candle I was holding sputtered once, and then died, leaving only a small trail of smoke behind.

“The vampire.” He was looking at me, definitely not surprised this time. “I see you were looking for my trinket. Have you come here to pillage my home? Is that why you freed me? Because you wished to loot the legendary treasure of Josiah Fenmoore, and instead stumbled upon his trapped spirit?”

The ghost, evidently named Josiah, floated closer to me. Despite the initial urge to bolt, I stood my ground. Scary as he might be, I was still a vampire, and I was hoping that perhaps he could be talked out of whatever he was planning. It was pretty much the only shot we had, since I’d already failed the plan and let him gather magic from one of his hidden caches.

“We just came here to catalog what was left behind after you died, Josiah. I’m an accountant, not an agent. I don’t know exactly what you were trying to do here, but it didn’t work. You don’t need to hang on like this. It’s okay to let go. To pass on.”

“Pass on?” Josiah’s face was growing more distinct by the moment, and I could see the fury in his eyes as he spat those words. “Do you have any idea the glory I was trying to bring to this world? The cleansing would have been perfection beyond words. I’ve spent my life communing with beings beyond the realm of human understanding, looking at the gorgeous chaos of their worlds and understanding how flawed ours was. My dream was to spread that beauty over the entire Earth, and just when I stood at the precipice of seeing it come to fruition, those damned agents showed up and ruined everything.”

He kept getting closer, and it took all of my self-control not to back away. Some part of my mind was looking at this as predator and prey, and if I flinched, it would mark me as the latter. I couldn’t do that, not if I wanted to keep any hope of controlling the situation.

“So I should just let it go, vampire? Move on? Forget a lifetime of effort because of one failure? Folly! One does not let a single setback keep them from success. We learn, adapt, and move forward, but never give up. And really, who are you to lecture me about passing on? You are a dead man who insists on walking about, subsisting off the blood of the living. Just a soul inside a corpse, nothing more. But I am glad it was you who found me, vampire.”

He’d closed the distance before I realized what he intended, his glowing hands already reaching out to grab me. “After all, one soul in a corpse is as good as any other, and once I take your flesh, I’ll be able to start my work anew.”

6.

Just when it seemed like Josiah was about to plunge those glowing hands through my sweater vest and into my sternum, they stopped. Sorry, they *were* stopped is more accurate. Sparks flashed across his fingers as a burst of light darted around me, driving the ghost momentarily back. He glowered at me, caught between surprise and fury.

“Protection charms?”

Right . . . Neil had cast some warding spells on me before we left for the basement. I’d never been entirely sure what those did, but apparently stopping ghost possession was one of the benefits. Josiah looked down at his hands, the green light momentarily burned away, and then back to me. “No matter. Such paltry wards cannot stand up to a focused effort, or a—hey!”

That last bit came because I’d dashed out the door midway through his monologue. Between the very clear threat that he thought the wards could be beaten and having a few seconds to put my thoughts in order, it became clear what the obvious course of action was: I had to get out of there, fast. Partially because, yes, standing around and letting him wear down my protection to try and steal my body was the height of idiocy, but also because I knew something Josiah didn’t: there was another vampire on the premises, and she didn’t have any protective spells around her. If he chanced upon Lillian before I could warn her, she could be in serious trouble. As would we, actually, since she was easily the strongest person in the castle.

There was no time to plot a course, not that I really could have even if I’d wanted to. Without the candle as guidance and no time to stop and look around, I had little idea of where I was heading. Rather than dwelling on it, I focused on moving. I could hear Josiah mumbling curses from behind me, though from how far back was impossible to say. He might be able to move through walls, but I was fairly certain he couldn’t see through them, so as long as I kept up my frantic pace, I could theoretically lose him.

It’s hard to say how long I was down there for, bolting around hallway after hallway, turn after turn. It all quickly ran together, and I could have easily been backtracking without realizing it. The only part that sticks out in my memory is when I dashed around a corner and found myself staring up at the loveliest thing I’d seen since entering this place: a set of stone steps leading upward. They were different than the ones I’d used to enter the basement; however, that was a blessing given how much sunlight had been around that first entrance. Without pause, I all but leapt up the stairs, my hand only slowing when it gripped the knob.

I had no way of knowing what was on the other side of this door, and while it probably wasn’t as immediately scary as a vengeful ghost, it might be far more dangerous. If it was in direct sunlight, I’d be burned before I had a

chance to leap back. Granted, I had some blood in my briefcase back at the library, and with what I'd brought, I could handle healing a minor injury. Still, that briefcase might be a long way from here, and that assumed I was quick and smart enough to only get partly scorched.

In the end, it was a simple equation. If I opened the door, I *might* get burned, but if Josiah found Lillian, we *would* be in serious danger. Better to play the odds—or at least, that was what I told myself as I pulled the door carefully open.

Shadows fell across my arm, and I nearly choked on the relief. Peering through, I saw a hallway with several overturned tables, a few patches of easily avoidable sunlight, and more claw marks along the ground. It was more beautiful than it had any right to be, and I darted out the door quickly, putting a touch more emphasis on moving silently as I sped along.

Navigating the castle in daytime was no small feat by itself, and more than once I had to turn back when I found myself staring down a patch of hallway completely filled with sunlight. Much as I enjoyed my silver immunity, I'd have traded it in a heartbeat to never fear another dawn. Since such bargains were not on the table, I resolved myself to doing the best I could with what I had and continued my trek.

Finally, I found myself looking at a stretch of rubble that seemed familiar, and I realized that I had nearly arrived at the library. Taking a few more turns, I blasted through the entrance, only to feel an object slam into my chest, sliding right between my ribs. I looked down to find the handle of a dagger sticking out from my sweater vest, still trembling in place.

"What the heck?" My eyes turned upward to find Neil, Albert, and Lillian all staring tensely at me. "I can't believe I have to ask this, but who just stabbed me?"

Neil raised his hand, not even bothering to look sheepish. "I wove a throwing charm on the dagger's handle, had it cocked to throw as soon as you came tearing in."

"That's the who and how. Now, if one of you could be bothered, I think I would very like to hear the why." Grabbing it in my hand, I yanked the dagger out. A small pool of blood formed on my sweater vest, although it was far less than a human would have yielded. Vampires could certainly bleed, just not as much as mortals. A sticky red residue of my own inner fluid was coating the blade, yet even through it, I could catch the barest whiff of silver.

"Neil said that you might not be you," Albert explained. He walked over with a hand towel, and I began the pointless endeavor of trying to mop up the blood from my clothes. Nothing short of an expert cleaner, or perhaps something magical from Amy, was going to get this stain out.

"When the ghost drained one of his magical implements, it made our candle go nuts," Neil explained. "Since we'd already found our item, it stood



to reason he'd gotten the one you were after. An amped-up planomancer wasn't going to let a perfectly good vessel get away, so we hightailed it back here and prepared to deal with you."

"You, uh . . . you okay there, Fredrick?" Lillian was eyeing me cautiously. She couldn't think I was really possessed, but her eyes wouldn't stop darting between the blade in my hand and the stain on my shirt. "You're healing that wound pretty fast."

Of course . . . I'd forgotten that Lillian wasn't in on my silver secret. Much as I might have loved to explain, this hardly seemed like the time or place, so I just shrugged my shoulders. "I've been keeping well-fed."

Whether she bought it or not—which she almost certainly didn't—was a matter that would have to wait. As I stood there, mopping up the last of my blood, I heard a gasp from Neil and saw Albert take a step back. It didn't take much to figure out what had happened, yet I still played into the theatrics and slowly turned around. I don't have any excuse for this, save only that it felt like what I should do in the moment.

Sure enough, floating above us was the still glowing form of Josiah Fenmore. On the upside, that probably meant he hadn't used the recovered power to free himself from the castle, but on the other hand, it meant he had all of that magic to throw at us. I spun around, putting myself directly between Lillian and Josiah. At least if he went for me, he'd have to break through the wards. Hopefully that would buy enough time for Neil to cast something.

"Josiah, I urge you one last time: pass on. Let go of this world. Move on to somewhere better. You can't really expect to defeat all of us."

He stared down at us, looking less intimidated than I would have preferred, and sneered. "You are no challenge to me, only tools to be wielded. With your flesh and strength, I shall repair what the agents destroyed, and this time, I will be ready when they come to interrupt me."

"Still want my body? Well then, come and try to take it. That's if you can break through my wards before my friends find a way to stop you, I mean." It was, admittedly, a risky gambit, but if I could keep Josiah distracted for even a minute, I was sure Neil would be able to bind him. Whether we liked each other or not, I respected his skill and trusted him to do what was right. In a pinch, Neil would come through. I truly believed that.

Which made it all the more worrisome when I heard his voice come from behind me. "Um, Fred . . . silver dagger, remember? That's enough to unravel all but the most serious of enchantments. Those wards are toast."

Josiah grinned with ghastly delight, as I whipped my head around and glared at Neil. "Perhaps that was something you might have shared with me before the ghost arrived. Or at least *out of his earshot*." The last few words came out as a hiss; my nerves were fraying as my vision darted

frantically between Neil and Josiah.

To my surprise, Neil was smiling too, even as Josiah flung himself forward with his hands outstretched. “Why would I? Come on, Fred, you’ve got this.”

Those were the last words to reach my ears before Josiah flung his whole being through my chest and took a firm grip on my very soul.

7.

Having two souls in the same body was not a pleasant experience by any stretch of the imagination. We both were there, yet not, and as we fought for control, bits and ends seemed to come loose. I found myself reliving some of Josiah's memories: of the first time he'd managed to cast a spell, of the day he brought a creature from another plane successfully over, and of the day the agents came.

That memory was the clearest, which was no surprise since it was the most recent. But it was also the most terrifying. I could see June and September sweeping through the lab, Josiah huddled in the corner. There was no levity or joy in June's face; her eyes were hard and cold. Frozen. Both of them moved with perfect teamwork and precision, gun in one hand and blade in the other. With their every motion, a creature fell, splitting open to reveal ashes inside, nothing like what lay inside the animals of our world. Then June turned, and those hard eyes were on me. No, on Josiah. She yelled something at him, urging him to give up, but instead, he raised his hands and tried to cast. For a moment, I caught a flicker of sadness behind those cold eyes, then the hand with her gun twitched and there was no more memory to watch.

Watching Josiah's death was draining, which only made matters worse. He was already the stronger of the two of us; I could feel my hold weakening. Soon, he'd get full control of my body, and when he did, I had no doubt he would cast me from it. Would I be a ghost then, as he'd been, or would I simply pass on as most of the dead did? It wasn't a question I was keen to find the answer to, so I redoubled my efforts and fought him every step of the way.

Why . . . why had Neil told him I was vulnerable? Why had he been so sure I would have the matter well in hand? Neil wouldn't betray me, not like this, not in front of Albert. I had to believe there was a way out, if only I could find it. He wouldn't be counting on me to overpower the ghost; Neil would never think so highly of my will. It had to be something tangible, something I could do. But what was there? All I had around me were a bunch of books and a bloody . . . knife. A bloody *silver* knife. And while I wasn't bothered by the stuff anymore, it still acted as a grounding agent for magic, which Josiah was almost entirely composed of. Sure, no normal vampire would risk plunging a silver dagger into himself, but he didn't know that I was no normal vampire.

Unfortunately, this realization came just as I was losing ground in the battle for control. He was winning, and it wouldn't take him much longer to grab that victory. So, rather than try and hold on, I abandoned control of everything else. All that I was, all that I had, went into my right arm. Using every last bit of willpower left, I twisted the blade around and jammed it back

into my chest.

Pain. Horrible pain. Not mine, but so close and tangible it may well have been. I could feel Josiah burning away, his magic unraveling as he futilely tried to find refuge from the poisonous metal that had been plunged into his nice new body. He tried to pull back, but he'd burrowed in too deeply, and with every passing second, more of his strength eroded. Finally, Josiah succeeded in pulling free, bursting out of me with an ear-splitting howl.

Though it was nearly drowned out in his scream, I still heard Neil mutter a few words of gibberish, and suddenly the howling stopped. For my part, I was slumped over on the floor, trying to remember how to move my own limbs. It's not a thing that generally requires much thought, until a vengeful ghost nearly ousts you from any connection to them. They were mine again, though, and as someone yanked the dagger from my chest, I could feel it slide free. My body was my own. Seconds later, Lillian appeared, tilting my flask into my mouth and pouring blood down my throat. Thankfully, I didn't need control to drink; my vampire instincts took care of that without hesitation.

Slowly, I came back to myself, eventually managing to sit up. Standing would take longer, but at least I could see the room. Josiah was floating nearby—a little too near, if I'm honest—opening his mouth and yelling as he slapped at an unseen barrier. His glow was almost entirely gone, the magic either destroyed by the silver or used to escape my body, with only the barest traces of green light dancing through his form. My eyes trailed lower, to where a chalk circle marked the boundary Josiah was struggling against.

"You had a trap for him."

"Dozens, actually." Neil pointed to the ground, and sure enough, there were identical circles chalked out all along the floor. "He could break through a holding circle with enough power, so we needed to drain him first. I assumed stabbing you would handle that, but when you showed up non-possessed, we had to think on our feet. Luckily, he took the bait and gave you another chance to weaken him."

"And when he came flying out, Neil sealed him in the first circle he passed through," Lillian added. She was still next to me, looking uncertain yet relieved. "Good thing you're such a badass about silver."

"Lillian, about that—"

"Not the time or the place, Fredrick. We've all got secrets. But let's worry about finishing our business first." She nodded to Josiah, who was still punching thin air, mouth opened in what I assumed was him cursing all of our names from here to hell. "What do we do about him?"

Neil walked around the chalk circle, eyeing it carefully. "This should hold for a while. If the agents don't have a way to deal with him, I can

reinforce the barrier with some extra magic, and then it will be enough to keep him contained indefinitely. He'll just stay in there—forever, or until he decides to move on. So, probably forever.”

“That’s kind of sad, when you think about it. Stuck in a prison he could escape, but he refuses to use the only way out,” Lillian said. It was a more sentimental thought than I expected from her, at least back when we first met.

“It’s not just sad, it’s wrong.” Albert was walking back from the other end of the library. Judging from the smear of blood on his hands, it seemed a fair guess that he’d been the one to pull the dagger from my chest. He was probably moving it far away from Lillian, putting safety first. “We can’t leave someone trapped like that. It’s cruel and inhumane.”

“You do realize this guy was trying to flood the world with monsters and usher in an apocalypse, right?” Neil pointed out.

Albert nodded. “And he paid for it with his life. Isn’t that enough? Should he really have to be trapped like this forever as well?”

When he put it like that, Albert had a point. Stopping Josiah had been one thing, leaving him bound like this, with no end in sight, felt wrong. But, feelings aside, there was the practicality to consider. “He’s too dangerous to let go, Albert. And he has the power to escape anytime he wants.”

“I know we can’t let him run free, but I also know he’s never going to take that chance to get away. Look at him. He’s all knotted up in anger, regret, and loneliness. The same things that put him on this path in life are keeping him here after death.”

“So, what would you like me to do?” Neil could clearly see Albert was conflicted about this; however, that didn’t mean Neil had any answers to offer. “I can manipulate, empower, and utilize the dead, but I can’t force them to move on. No necromancer can. That’s not the way our magic works.”

The sound of metal ringing filled the air, and I knew before my eyes made the journey that Albert had drawn his sword. “I know you can’t, Neil. But maybe I can.”

Before anyone could react, Albert took a step toward the chalk circle. That was enough to kick Neil into gear, as he bolted forward and planted himself directly in front of Albert.

“Whoa there. What are you talking about? Yes, you’ve got a magic sword, but do you have any idea what you’re doing? You can’t just . . . cut through someone’s connection to our plane like the string on a balloon.”

“I cut the chimera without hurting it,” Albert reminded him. “I don’t see how this is any different.”

“Really? Because I can walk through the basic theorems of how amazingly different they are in a couple of hours, and you’ll see—” The words faltered as Albert raised his free hand and placed it on Neil’s shoulder.

“I can do this. I believe it with all my heart. This is the sort of thing my sword was made for. So please, trust me.”

They stood like that for several seconds, until finally, Neil moved wordlessly to the side. Albert smiled at him, then began walking forward once more. Part of me wanted to run over and do what Neil had given up on: talk some sense into my assistant before he got into trouble. For all he knew, Josiah would break free, or possess him, or pull some other trick out of his ghostly sleeves. But instead, I just sat there with Lillian and watched. Whether I thought it was smart, or even possible, was irrelevant. Albert said it could be done, and he was the one with the sword.

He was the Unlikely Champion.

Albert didn't pause until he was at the edge of the circle, staring into the still silently screaming mouth of Josiah. Lifting his sword carefully, he met the ghost's eyes with his own and pulled back to swing. Just before he let loose, Albert whispered a trio of words in the softest of voices, probably only audible to Lillian and me.

“We forgive you.”

Then he swung. The sword sliced past the unseen barrier, which was no surprise, and slid into Josiah's form. There, however, it slowed as if it had hit something dense, yet never stopped. The blade kept inching along, and as it did, Josiah began to burn with a new light. This one wasn't pale and green like the power he'd been carting around. It was a golden-white that seemed to flow from where the edge of the sword was moving through him. The deeper the sword went, the brighter the glow, until it didn't seem like light at all. It was a searing fire, burning through Josiah's soul. Whether it was because our spirits had so recently shared a body or the magic of Albert's sword, I had no idea, but as I sat there, I could see it destroying the worst parts of him. His anger, his stubbornness, his fear, all the pieces that were keeping him bound to a place he no longer belonged, each was burned away one by one in the power of the sword's glow.

Finally, the swing finished, and Albert's blade came out the other side. The light faded, and once more, we were staring at the intangible form of Josiah. He seemed different now, his face no longer clouded in madness and fury. Looking over each of us, he stopped at Albert, and mouthed the words, “Thank you.” With no more warning than that, his form began to unravel, turning to little more than smoke and drifting upward toward the ceiling.

Seconds later, no trace of Josiah remained, save for the chalk circle that could no longer contain him.

8.

With Josiah handled, the rest of our work went smoothly. Well, that's not entirely true. Things calmed down for about two hours, after which June burst through the front door, gun in hand, looking like she'd come ready for war. Apparently my text to Krystal had gone through once I was aboveground, and she'd reached out to June since she was the closest agent in the vicinity. Once we'd assured her that the issues were indeed handled, she put the gun away long enough to hear what had happened. Neil turned over the sealed candle, as well as the totem he and Albert had recovered—a small bell with runes all over it—and June headed off to give it to whomever dealt with that sort of thing.

Other than that bit of business, we went back to handling our respective tasks. Bit by bit, items were catalogued and stored for pick-up. In a surprising stroke of luck, Albert even managed to find an old checkbook under a table. While not a lot to work from, it did allow me to hunt down Josiah's accounts and get some semblance of his finances, not that there was a lot find. It seemed he had spent almost the entirety of the Fenmoore fortune on the equipment we'd seen downstairs, and in fact had a couple of creditors with debts to collect. I wasn't sure how that would work with the Agency seizing the estate, and I didn't need to figure it out. My job was just to compile the information; someone else would have to actually deal with it.

As we worked, I kept expecting Lillian to broach the subject of my unusual ability to walk off being stabbed by silver; however, that moment never came. She just kept plugging along with the rest of us, cheerful and attentive, doing her best to learn on the job. By the final day, I'd gotten so anxious over the seemingly inevitable discussion that I'd turned jumpy, startling slightly every time someone drew near. So when a hand finally clapped on my shoulder, causing me to nearly drop the papers I was holding, my body flooded with relief. This wouldn't be a fun conversation, but it would feel good to have it done with.

That relief faded as I turned around and found myself looking not at Lillian, but instead at Albert. He'd been quiet since the incident with Josiah, still smiling but without his usual air of joviality. I'd suspected that this was coming as well; I just thought it would happen once we were back in Winslow. One look at his eyes told me I was wrong, however. He was ready to tackle the issue here and now. I glanced around the room, noting that it was empty.

"Neil and Lillian are loading up the van," Albert explained. "I asked for a few minutes to talk to you, just boss and assistant."

"Then by all means, Albert. Let's talk." I set the pages I was holding down gently, and then made my way over to some of the few unbroken chairs

we'd found in our exploration of the castle. They were mismatched and largely uncomfortable, but they held our weight, and that was all a chair really needed to do. I took my seat, and Albert did the same, although he had to pause to adjust his sword before finding a comfortable position. He kept adjusting, and I realized he was stalling, his nerve momentarily faltering. It was a dilemma I'd faced many times as well, so I didn't force him to recover. Instead, I broached the subject myself.

"This is about our last discussion, I assume. Whether or not you should stay in my employ. Tell me what you're thinking, Albert. It's okay if you don't have a fully formed response yet. You're more than welcome to bounce thoughts and ideas off of me."

He looked visibly relieved, finally ceasing the sword adjustment and sitting still. "I gave what you said a lot of thought. I really did. About what I should be doing with myself, and my sword. And I had decided that I was going to keep on working for you. This sword might have a destiny, but I don't have to give up my free will for it. The blade chose me, not the other way around. We do good, you know? I mean, you do, and I get to be part of that. I see it when I drop stuff off with clients. You give them a sense of security where their money is concerned, and it takes a big weight off their shoulders. I like being a piece of that process, no matter small. You asked me if I was happy, if this was the path I wanted to be on, and my answer was yes to both. I loved this job not because it's comfortable, but because I got to make the world a little better by doing it."

Touching as the words were—and make no mistake, it took all I had not to look away or stammer—there was a detail within them that didn't escape my notice. "You're speaking about all of that in the past tense, as though it's no longer true."

"It's all still true," Albert protested, his words coming quickly. "All of it. I just . . . I realized something else while we were on this job. When I cut the ghost free and helped him move on. No one else could have done that, could they? Neil said necromancers didn't have that ability. So none of the others, not even Arch or Krystal or Amy, could have set that man free. I don't know a lot about this sword, even after all the training I've done, but Arch tells me that Weapons of Destiny have power outside the normal range of what's possible. They can do amazing, incredible things. And for better or worse, this one *did* choose me."

He paused, his eyes drifting over to the table where we'd sorted dozens of pages cataloguing the castle's contents, most of which had been hauled up by him. "I love working for you, Fred. I love what you do, but the truth is that my part in it is a small one. With a little training, anyone could do it. Things like the ghost, sword-things . . . there might only be a handful of people in the world who can do those, and I'm one of them. I just keep



thinking . . . how many other people like Josiah are out there? In need of help that nobody else can offer? That's a really scary thought; I've never had responsibility on that level. Heck, I barely had any at all when I was alive. But I asked myself, if the sword had picked you, Fred—if you were the one wielding all this power—what would you do with it? And I know this is the choice you would make.”

“I appreciate the kind sentiment, Albert, but I think you're giving me a bit too much credit.”

Albert shook his head. “No, I'm not. You always step up when someone needs you, and that's the kind of man I want to be. So I'm going to step up, for all the people out there who need the kind of help only this sword can offer them. I'm going to . . . I mean, I guess I am . . . Fred, I have to quit working for you.”

“I know.” Despite the fact that my emotions were reeling—an issue not at all helped by Albert looking like he was fighting back tears—I did my best to keep an even, comforting voice. This had to be hard enough on Albert as it was; he didn't need me making things worse. No, what he needed was reassurance that everything would be okay. I wasn't honestly sure if it would be, the path he was choosing was a dangerous one, but that was irrelevant. He just needed to believe things would turn out okay, if only for a little while, and as his friend, it was the least I could do. “You have been a wonderful employee, and it is with a heavy heart that I accept your resignation as such. But I hope you know that you will still be one of my dearest friends, no matter where your new role takes you.”

He smiled softly, the tears losing the battle to his willpower and retreating momentarily. “Thanks. But I don't think I'll be going anywhere for a while, at least not permanently. Winslow is my home, it's where all the people I care about live. Besides, Neil is part of my team, and I couldn't tear him away from Amy. Maybe I'll get to do the occasional trip to Boarback for training, but we live at Charlotte Manor, and that's how I want it to stay. For now, anyway.”

While Arch would probably protest, Albert's eyes were locked in resolve. Even though I knew it was selfish, the news still lightened my heart. Saying goodbye to Albert in one capacity was bad enough; I loathed the idea of losing him from my daily life altogether. But even as he spoke, part of me knew I needed to start steeling myself for that inevitability. Whatever destiny that sword planned to drag him toward, it would no doubt take him beyond the boundaries of Colorado. When that day came, it would be our job to assure him that no matter how far he wandered, he could also come back to a home. He needed a safety net, not an anchor. However, I hoped that day wouldn't arrive for a very long while.

We chatted a little more, and then I scooped up a closed box of files

and headed off to the van, passing Neil in the entrance. Neither of us said anything, merely exchanging a brief look. I had no doubt he knew what Albert and I had been talking about, and was on his way to cheer his friend up. At least Albert wouldn't have to face his destiny alone; of all the things I could say about Neil, he was loyal above all else. So long as he could move, he would take every step of that journey at Albert's side.

The moon was high as I walked across the grass, making my way to the van. Lillian sat on the bumper, looking up at the sky. She tilted her head down slightly as I approached, eyes still trained upward.

"Did you two finish your little chat?"

"We did indeed." I set the box down carefully in the van's rear, nestling it in with a dozen other identical containers. "It seems I'm going to have to find myself a new assistant."

"You had to know it was coming, Fredrick. That boy has been bound for greater things since the first day he pulled a Weapon of Destiny out of its sheath."

"I disagree." Shutting the rear door, I took a seat next to Lillian on the bumper. Albert and Neil would emerge when they were ready to deal with other people once more. Until then, I could give them space. Besides, Albert's courage had inspired me. I had my own tasks to attend to. "Albert has been bound for greater things long before he set his hands on that blade."

"Maybe so," she replied.

"Lillian, I'm immune to silver." The words burst forth, and I paused for a reaction of shock and surprise, but none came. Instead, she just kept looking skyward, giving me the slightest of nods.

"I figured that out already, but thanks for finally coming clean. I don't suppose you'd mind telling me how?"

"If I could, I would. The truth is, no one is entirely sure how such a thing is possible. But I'll freely tell you what happened to me, along with anything else you want to know." I hesitated, then pressed forward. "I owe you that. You left your clan, trusting in me to provide a home for you, and by keeping this secret, I haven't reciprocated that trust. I'm sorry, Lillian. All of this is new to me, but that's not an excuse. I need to do better, and I'm going to give my all to accomplish that. Just bear with me if I make some missteps along the way."

Finally, her eyes left the stars, and her entire face pinched in laughter. It wasn't uproarious, merely a soft, shaking chuckle that seemed to stretch on for a full minute. "Sorry, sorry. I don't mean to act like I don't appreciate the sentiment. It's just funny to me. I left a clan where they'd keep us from blood for weeks at a time for the slightest infraction, and came to one where the leader is feeling guilty for not immediately sharing a pretty huge secret with the newest member. Maybe funny is the wrong word. 'Wonderfully absurd'

captures it better. I didn't think there were clans like this one. You really love all these people who stood with you, don't you?"

"With all that I have," I told her.

"Good. Because I've seen the way most of them look at you, and it seems like the feeling is mutual." Her eyes opened and turned to me as she jammed an elbow gently into my ribs. "Now, enough with the build-up. Tell me how the hell you got yourself immune to silver."

With a night sky overhead and nothing to do while we waited for the others, now seemed as good a time as any to tell her the story of what happened the night I helped save Gideon.

"Ah, that. Well, as I said, we don't understand how it's possible, but we do know the cause: dragon magic."

Her eyes got wider, and a sharp smile split her face. "Ohhh shit. This is going to be good."

## **An Appraisal in the Carnival**

1.

The headlights of Bubba's truck lit the metal fence, bound together by thick chains and sealed with a massive padlock. Beyond the obstacle, I could see faded blotches of red, yellow, green, and blue all dotting the shadowy landscape. The colors matched the rest of the decor, which is to say it all looked old and worn. Here and there, my eyes caught sight of some bits of metal that still shone or a tent without frayed edges; however, these were the rare exceptions amidst a veritable ocean of lost splendor.

"Honest first impression: the curb appeal is going to need a lot of work."

"It's an abandoned carnival; we knew that much going in." Bubba looked out the window, squinting slightly. His night-vision wasn't quite on the same level as my own, so it took more effort for him to see what lay on the other side of that fence. "But you ain't exactly wrong either." He killed the engine, and the two of us stepped out of his truck and into the night air.

Despite the theoretically festive nature of the destination, Bubba and I were both at the carnival to work. Richard Alderson, head of the local tribe of therians and a man we both considered to be a friend, had been approached by one of his people looking for a loan to restore this place, having recently inherited it from a dead family member. (If it seems strange that someone would approach the head of a supernatural organization for money, please do keep in mind that parahumans are both poor record keepers in general and held to different tax codes than regular people, making it exceedingly difficult to just go get a loan from a bank. I'd been taken aback as well, yet it seems such things happen all the time.) Richard, however, was not a man to invest his money foolishly, and had therefore hired Bubba and I to come out and do an evaluation of the premises.

Bubba was to check over the mechanical issues and see what repairs would run, while I was supposed to evaluate the facilities as a whole and calculate the potential revenue stream. It was, admittedly, a bit outside my wheelhouse, and I'd told Richard as much, but it was closer to my specialty than anyone else he knew, so I'd still been given the job. I could hardly say no after that, both because Richard was asking as a favor, and because his tribe and my clan were officially aligned together. It was another layer of protection against the Turvas, one that needed protecting, though honestly, I'd have probably taken the job anyway. While Lillian had proven more than skilled enough to make up for the extra work after losing Albert, things still weren't quite the same as they had been. I missed having him around. Though we still saw each other at Charlotte Manor with some regularity, it just wasn't the same. Much of his time was spent training with Arch these days, and even now, they were on a trip to Boarback for a week. Getting myself out of the

office was a nice change of pace, and spending the time with friends made it all the more enjoyable.

“Here he comes.” Bubba nodded up the long, winding dirt road to where a pair of headlights could be seen slicing through the darkness. This place’s location, no doubt chosen to keep any other businesses from complaining about the noise and lights, was somewhat out of the way. That was going to be a hurdle if they wanted to reopen the establishment, one of nearly a dozen I’d mentally tallied before we were even through the front gate.

The vehicle moved slowly, taking every bump with extreme care, until it circled the last bend and came into full view. I’ll admit it; I stared in shock at what appeared before us, my mouth hanging slightly agape. Of all the cars I’d imagined Richard might drive—massive monster trucks or luxurious stretch limos, mostly—this one had never even entered the competition.

Richard Alderson, head of Winslow’s therian tribe, host to the King of the West, and all-around imposing figure, pulled his minivan to a stop only a few feet away from Bubba’s truck. When he popped the door and stood up, it made a little more sense. This minivan had been modified to accommodate his incredible size, as Richard towered over pretty much everyone and had so much muscle he’d have made every other participant in a bodybuilding competition immediately admit defeat. Then he yanked the sliding side door open, and the vehicle choice became a perfect fit. Because, above all the other things I listed already, Richard was a father, and minivans tended to have exceptional safety features.

Sally Alderson, Richard’s daughter, bounded out the side of the minivan, eyes shining as she raced to the front gate and stared into the carnival’s depths. It was curious; despite all the grime and general wear the place had suffered, she still seemed utterly entranced by the idea of a carnival of any sort. From behind her, moving at a steady pace that in no way matched his childish form, was Gideon. An ancient dragon who had taken the appearance of a child, there was something unsettling about him, even before one caught sight of his lavender eyes and dangerous smile. Gideon was terrifying, easily the scariest person or creature I’d ever encountered, yet he was also dedicated. He had taken up the role of Sally’s playmate, best friend, and guardian, and to my knowledge, none who’d ever tried to harm her had lived to see another sunset.

“You brought Sally?” Bubba asked.

“Wasn’t planning on it, but once she heard I was coming to look over a carnival, she got all excited . . .” Richard rubbed the back of his neck and glanced down, slightly embarrassed. The man could stand toe-to-toe with nearly any parahuman and never flinch; however, even he was weak when it

came to his daughter. “She’s never been able to go to a real one—with crowds that size it’s just too dangerous—so since this place is empty, I thought it would be okay.”

“A real one would be fine as well,” Gideon said, standing a ways back from Sally as she pressed against the gate so hard I began to fear she might accidentally push her head through. Though, given all the parahuman strength we had on hand, snapping a few metal bars wouldn’t even be an inconvenience. “I would make sure she was unharmed.”

“We tried that once, Gideon. You left so much blood on the glass, they had to close the aquarium for a month,” Richard reminded him.

Gideon merely shrugged. “I assumed thoroughly discouraging the first attempt to take her would give any who planned on trying again reason to reconsider the idea.”

“Daddy! Can we go inside?” Sally had finally turned from the gate and was looking back at us.

“One moment. Daddy just has to get the key.” Richard patted his pockets, eventually coming up with a moderately sized key that looked positively diminutive in his massive hand. “Okay, guys, let’s do a nice, thorough check of the property. Lonnie—that’s the wererat asking for the loan—says his grandpa built and ran this place for a few decades. Started as a cover for a moonshining operation in the woods, hence the location, but ended up making enough to turn it into a legitimate business. Even after the people stopped coming, he had enough of a soft spot for the old joint that he kept paying a maintenance company to come out and keep the carnival from falling down, which means it should be mostly safe. Plus, the place still has power, so the first thing we need to do is find the main office and turn on the juice. That should give us an idea of what works and what doesn’t.”

“Sally and I will be amusing ourselves with rides and games,” Gideon announced.

Bubba looked over at the carnival. “Hate to tell you this, but even with occasional maintenance and power, I doubt any of these old rides are still working.”

“I’ve made things move under my will since long before you humans managed to bend lightning to your bidding. Sally wishes to have a genuine carnival experience, so that is what she will receive.” Gideon started forward toward the gate, as though the conversation was concluded. Which I guess it was, for him, and that meant it was done for the rest of us, too. Gideon spoke with us only when he deemed it worth doing, and even that was a sizable courtesy.

The rest of us followed him over, and Richard began fumbling with the lock. It was old, but sturdy, probably one of the last few well-constructed items in the entire park. Now that I was closer, I could see that despite the

place being run-down, it was surprisingly clean, and the lingering scent of human still danced in the air. The maintenance company had clearly just been out, perhaps even that day. Well, at least Lonnie was smart enough to put his best foot forward; that spoke to someone who cared about the project he was undertaking. If the maintenance was thorough, and the attractions were not in need of dire repairs, this might just be something worth putting money into.

“Get in the—damn it.” Richard’s shoulders slumped, and in his hand I could see the snapped off remains of a key. “Must be rusted or something. I couldn’t get it to fit right. Fred, do me a favor and make a note that we need to buy Lonnie a new lock.” Before I could even take out my notepad to jot the order down, there was a muted *crunch* and Richard was tossing the broken remains of a lock to the ground.

He pulled the chain through the gate’s bars easily, then yanked the massive metal structure open as if it were made of cardboard. “Welcome to the carnival. Please enjoy yourselves, and remember to be safe above all else.”

That last part seemed aimed at Gideon, who met Richard’s stare without so much as a flinch. “As if you needed to tell me that.” Gideon took Sally’s hand, and together, the two of them bolted off into the darkness. Part of me wanted to call out for them to stop, to wait for the adults so it would be safe, but that was ridiculous. Not only was Gideon older than all of us combined, he was also far and away the most powerful. The truth of the matter was that Sally was worlds safer at his side than ours.

As they darted off, Richard pulled a small map from his back pocket and looked it over. “I think the main office is to the north. Should be a quick walk. Let’s get the power on and start checking this place out.”



2.

Finding the main office was a relatively painless process—the walkways were clear of debris, and most of the signs pointing to rides and attractions were still in place. True, the paint had chipped and writing had faded; however, the bones were still there. The longer I looked at this place, trying to see it through the lens of what it could be rather than what it was, the more convinced I became that it might be salvageable. Of course, most of the real information we'd need on that front was going to come from Bubba. Paint and tents were one thing; if the rides were in need of serious overhaul, that was a whole other level of cost.

We'd found the office and were nearly inside when light suddenly filled up the sky. From our vantage point, we could see over the tops of the other booths and attractions to the Ferris wheel, which was burning brightly in the night sky as it began to play music and slowly turned in place. I was amazed it moved so fluidly, and that all the lights worked. Then I remembered that we had yet to actually turn the power on, and it made much more sense.

"Gideon?" I asked.

"Unless Sally has suddenly gotten much better at magic, I'd say that's a fair guess," Richard replied. "We'll check that one out once they're done with it."

Stepping inside, we made our way through the small building, passing up the nurse's station and a tiny office with a desk that took up nearly all the space, arriving at a door that led down to a basement. Once inside, Richard and Bubba turned a few knobs and flipped a large switch that would have taken a normal person both arms to move. A soft hum of power filled the room, and overhead, several bulbs flickered and began to glow.

"Huh, thought those would have been dead by now," Bubba noted. "Does maintenance turn the power on when they come out here?"

"Given how easily that switch moved and the lack of dust around here, I'm guessing so," Richard said. "Now that we've got some juice flowing, what do you want to start with?"

"Makes the most sense to start with the big-ticket items. Don't mean shit if the deep fryers are an easy fix but the roller coaster needs thousands of dollars of work."

"I think I'll look at the food stalls," I said. "Concessions are going to be a big part of the overall income stream, after admittance fees and ride tickets, so getting a sense of what the place is equipped for, along with what it could potentially handle, will give us a good idea of whether or not that can help keep the carnival in the black."

Richard checked his map once more. "Looks like there's a spinning ride not far from the Ferris wheel, and right next to it was a big café that sold .

.. hot chowder?” His nose wrinkled slightly. “I think I’m starting to see why this carnival closed in the first place. Anyway, why don’t we head there? Bubba can check the ride, Fred can look over the café, and I can make sure Gideon isn’t levitating the Ferris wheel halfway to the clouds.”

I was reasonably sure that Richard was joking—not that Gideon couldn’t do such a thing; I just presumed he wouldn’t be that ostentatious—however, I didn’t ask for confirmation as we made our way up from the basement and out of the building. Through the years, I’d learned that the less I knew about what the ancient dragon wanted and could do, the happier I was overall.

It took a few turns to make our way toward the Ferris wheel—which was still brightly lit and easy to see, but required navigating around the rest of the area to get to—however, we eventually made it. Sure enough, there was the spinning ride Richard had mentioned. A surprisingly intact sign above the platform labeled it the “Lunch Thief,” which was a name that both conveyed what it would do to those who rode and made me wonder who on earth would ever get on such a thing. Rebranding was going to be critical for a lot of these elements, it seemed, if the carnival was going to make money once more. I made a few notes as I walked away from the Lunch Thief, which Bubba was already pulling up panels on so he could dig around inside.

The café was indeed directly by the Lunch Thief, just around a corner which in no way would have obscured the sounds of people losing their stomach contents or blocked the smell of cooking chowder from those on the ride. It was like the exact opposite of synergy, and part of me couldn’t help wondering if the whole set-up was an intentionally cruel joke played by the original owner. Location aside, though, the café had actually held up rather well, despite years of abandonment. Most of the tables and chairs were a loss, which meant the whole lot would need replacing, but since they were the cheap plastic kind, it was a relatively minor expense. It was a nice space overall, with plenty of room to host lots of folks taking a break to get food. Near the edge of the seating was a slightly blocked off area that looked as though it had been used for storage. With minimal restructuring, I imagined it could host a stage instead, something to provide some live—or even pre-recorded—music to block out any sounds making their way over from the Lunch Thief.

Inside the café, I found things in similar condition. There was wear, sure, and some dust, but minimal rusting and rot. While Bubba would need to come check all the appliances over to be sure, it looked from a cursory glance like the place could be easily salvaged. It would need to start serving something other than chowder, obviously, but that was an easy fix. Maybe it could focus on smells not so taxing to the senses of those being spun around a ride. Sandwiches, fried foods, things like that. Actually, why not pick

something with a fragrance that might be an aid, rather than a hindrance? Homemade ginger snaps would fill the air with a pleasant scent, and make a good nausea aid for those who'd already ridden the Lunch Thief.

I stooped down to examine the counter space, mentally trying to find space for two extra ovens, and that was when I heard it: the sound of footsteps racing along outside. I'd have assumed it was Sally and Gideon, except that there was only one set of feet, and they were much too heavy to belong to a child. Or a dragon masquerading as a child. Hauling myself back up, I peered through the dirty windows and out into the eating area, trying to pin down the source of the steps. I'd nearly located them when a new noise burst through the air, loud screeches of terrible rock music obscuring every other sound nearby.

Darting out the door, I looked around, only to find the same empty café I'd left moments prior. With horrid guitar and off-beat drums in my ears, it was impossible to hear even my own thoughts, so I followed the noise back over to its source: the Lunch Thief. It was spinning out as Bubba smacked at something on the controls, with Richard a few feet away covering his ears. Both of them appeared to be in pain, until Bubba finally found the right button, which mercifully ended the noise and caused the ride to slow down.

"Well," Bubba said, speaking much louder than he actually needed to, "the good news is that this one still mostly works. Bad news is that if we don't find a way to install a better soundtrack, no one's going to get within a mile of the damn thing."

"Make that two miles for therians." Richard rubbed his temples and shook his head, sending his long golden hair spraying around. "Did Lonnie's grandfather owe some garage band a favor, or did he just genuinely hate his own customers?"

"Given that he put a chowder café next to a ride designed to make people queasy, I'm leaning toward the latter," I said. "But I've got good news, too. It looks like the café is in good shape overall. If Bubba gives the thumbs up on the appliances, you're looking at a solid venue in need of mostly cosmetic alterations."

Bubba patted the Lunch Thief's console gently, careful not to accidentally turn the music back on. "Same here. Needs some tweaks, and some safety features added, but overall, it ain't too bad."

"That's surprising, and encouraging." Richard finally stopped rubbing his ears, though he watched the ride warily, as if he didn't trust it not to spring back to life. "Lonnie may just get his money yet. Anyway, Sally and Gideon are still on the Ferris wheel, and after that, they're going to the carousel, so I think our next stop should be the Haunted Fun House. There's a whole row of small food booths by it, and if the mechanics are in good condition, it could be a major draw."

“Lead the way.” I paused, remembering why I’d originally darted out of the café to begin with. “Hey, Richard, did you run over here before the music started?”

“I was on my way,” he told me. “Run might be a strong word for it, though. Why, did you hear something?”

“I thought so. It sounded like someone running.”

Richard and Bubba exchanged a brief look. “You hear anything?” Richard asked.

“Had my head in the guts of this machine,” Bubba replied. “May have been a wild animal; bound to be some holes in the fence around here somewhere.”

“Hmm.” Richard glanced back at the café, then to me, and then back to Bubba. “It could have been me; my natural pace is brisker than most people’s. Since I didn’t hear anything either, that seems like the most likely explanation. Still, everyone keep an eye open just in case. Places like this sometimes draw in unsavory sorts of parahumans. It’s unlikely, since the maintenance company is regularly coming through here without incident, but anything is possible.”

“Should we tell Gideon?” I asked.

Richard hesitated, then shook his head. “I don’t think that’s necessary quite yet. All we have are a set of footsteps that might have been mine. I don’t smell anything out of the ordinary, plus Gideon is virtually impossible to sneak up on. If I told them, all it would do is scare Sally, and I’d like her to enjoy this. It may be the only time she can go to a carnival without Gideon having to kill someone. Let’s just all keep our eyes peeled and our wits about us. Should we actually discover something dangerous, we can decide how to proceed from there. Until then, we focus on the job at hand.”

It made sense, and the more time went by, the less sure I was about the speed the steps had been moving. Richard was probably right; I’d just overheard him and mistaken the pace. Not every place I went was some seedy parahuman nest waiting to attack. Sometimes, an old carnival was just an old carnival, and if Richard financed the restoration, it wouldn’t even be old for much longer. I was almost certainly just being paranoid.

At least, that’s what I told myself as we headed off toward the Haunted Fun House.

3.

Unlike the café, the long line of food booths weren't nearly as well persevered. Then again, since they'd been constructed from canvas and cheap lumber, that wasn't especially surprising. Bubba gave the machines inside a once-over—what few appliances there were to be found—and declared that while some might still work, they were so old and had seen enough exposure to the elements that using them would almost certainly be a safety violation. I wasn't as put off by the news as might be expected though, because, in truth, I could see more potential for this area than just a string of unconnected food stalls.

I imagined it would be cheaper to create one centralized kitchen and use the booths only to host service personnel, each one offering a single specialty item. That would spread the lines out, give more room for clerks at each respective booth, and overall increase the general speed and potential profit. Plus, we could update the menu offerings. I couldn't read many of the signs left, but it was hard to imagine "Hot Cherries on a Stick" and "Fried Bubblegum" were quite the draws they'd once been.

Despite my initial hesitation to take on this job for Richard, I found myself getting more and more enthralled with it. I'd been in many businesses through the years, usually just working on their books; however, it seemed I'd picked up a small bit of practical knowledge here and there. While he'd clearly need to bring in a real specialist to get things optimized, I was having fun working outside my usual boxes.

Perhaps that cheerful mood was why I followed along with Richard and Bubba as they headed to the Haunted Fun House, straying from my proper duties to take in one the carnival's main attractions. It was certainly an imposing structure, built to resemble a Gothic manor, though only in the most cheap and cursory of ways. A small track with a line of three cars meant to seat two people each was set in front, flanked by a wide pair of doors on either side. Further over, off to the left, was a massive arc of a doorway closed off by a door so tall even Richard could pass through without ducking. It was painted pure black, a feature that would have been far more intimidating if not for the chips showing the oak color underneath.

"Looks like they decided to save space and combine two attractions into one." Richard surveyed the structure carefully, no doubt checking for any outward signs of decay—aside from the decorative ones, obviously. "The cars probably take you through a standard haunted house with stuff jumping out, and I bet the door leads up to the usual fun house fare, probably with a spooky theme. Given that space is at a premium in these sorts of places, it's not a bad idea."

As Richard had been speaking, Bubba walked over and fiddled with

the control panel. The sound of cackling laughter filled the air as lights flickered on and the attraction sprang to life. Mercifully, this was not a repeat of the Lunch Thief's soundtrack, as the laughing quickly gave way to someone doing a terrible Vincent Price impersonation, beckoning people to come inside if they thought they could survive.

"Want to see if we can take this thing for a ride?" Bubba gently tugged on the lead cart to see if it could move. "We can roll through and write down everything that don't light up or jump out, then I can walk the tracks afterward and see how much work they need. Be a lot faster than checkin' it all one piece at a time."

"Is that safe?" My eyes were on the cart that, while seemingly able to move, certainly didn't appear as if it had done so in many years.

"Not for most people, but I can't imagine there'd be much in there that could hurt us," Bubba replied.

Richard walked over and began easing himself down into one of the cars, filling the space meant for two and then some. There was a lot of creaking and groaning, but nothing snapped or broke apart, so that seemed like a good sign. "I'm glad to go if you can actually make this thing move, Bubba." After a few more seconds of adjustment, Richard turned to me. "Fred, would you mind checking the upstairs? Just note anything broken that needs fixing, or anything mechanical that Bubba needs to check out when we're done down here. It will save us a lot of time."

"Happy to help," I told him, because I was, and because I'd have done it even if that wasn't the case. Fun as this trip was, I was still being paid to do a job, and that meant following the boss's orders. Especially when he was nice enough to frame them as requests.

I walked up to the chipped black door, preparing to use as much strength as needed to shove the massive thing open. To my surprise, however, it took only the barest of pushes to send it moving inward. Grabbing the knob, I wiggled the door back and forth for a few moments, trying to figure out why it was so easy to move. The best I could figure out was that the wood was especially light, and there appeared to be some special hinge at the top of the entrance helping it along. I chided myself for not expecting something so mundane; this was supposed to be used by humans, after all. My time with Krystal and the others had given me a predisposition to seeing everything through a parahuman lens, it seemed. But this was just a fun house inside a carnival, one of countless thousands throughout the nation that normal people went to every year. Even I'd visited a few, back when the traveling ones came through my hometown. They hadn't been a favorite pastime—I was never much of one for large crowds; however, in high school, it was an occasional entertaining diversion.

Making my way up the stairs, which were also painted black with the

exception of two that had been replaced by new boards, I scanned the narrow entrance, searching for any areas with structural compromise or mechanical components. Bubba was right. While we were in little danger wandering a potentially unsound attraction, the same wouldn't be true once the carnival had human guests. They were such fragile creatures, really. The longer I spent as a vampire, the harder it was to believe I'd survived as long as I had with a normal body. Sure, I had to worry about stakes, sunlight, and supernatural threats, but the overall number of things that could harm or kill me had shrunk to a fraction of its former size. No wonder the older vampires I'd met seemed so inhuman; if I wasn't still around humans, it would be easy to forget what I'd once been.

When I crested the staircase, I found myself staring at a man. A pale man—thoroughly unremarkable, if I'm honest—wearing a sweater vest and khakis. Me, in other words. It seems the first attraction of the fun house was a classic: a hall of mirrors for guests to bump their way around in.

Allow me to digress for a brief moment, because while I've never explicitly covered this before, I'm sure some of you will be wondering at just how I was able to see myself in a mirror when vampires are supposed to lack reflections. The simplest answer is that the whole thing is bunk. How would that even work? Assuming our flesh was magically not to be seen in a mirror, which is a silly premise to start with, why would our clothes be absent as well? Does donning a shirt as a vampire somehow transfer some aspect of vampirism to the shirt, but only for the length of time that it stays on our skin? The whole premise is quite strange. As near as I can figure, and this is pure conjecture on my part, the rumor started because there was a time when a "mirror" was just a large hunk of polished silver, which vampires *would* of course avoid for obvious reasons. Still, that is only a guess; I have no certain idea as to where such an odd rumor came from.

At any rate, I found myself standing in a hall of mirrors, and proceeded to do what I'd been instructed: make my way through it. A steady thrum of ghostly music and standard spooky sounds played from speakers on the walls, likely meant to instill a bit of terror as I wandered about. Cackling laughter, like at the entrance, heavy panting, doors slamming, wailing moans, muffled footsteps, unintelligible whispers, all the usual stuff one would find on a \$3 Halloween album. When I listened carefully—a feat I rarely engaged in—I could make out the same music being played downstairs as well. Why pay for two soundtracks when they could just run the audio to different outlets? Food aside, I found myself with a bit of respect for the previous owner of this place. Pragmatism and creativity were always aspects to admire in an entrepreneur.

The whole area was something of a boon as well, since nearly all the mirrors were still in one piece. True, several were dusty, and occasionally I

would find a shattered one with broken shards shimmering on the ground, but overall, it wouldn't cost much to replace the few that were needed. If the rest of this fun house was in as good of shape, it was yet another tick in favor of making the investment.

Turning a corner near what I assumed had to be the end of the mirrors, I once again found myself looking at a man. This one wasn't me, however. It was someone in dark jeans, a heavy coat, and with their face obscured by a bleached cat mask speckled with dirt. I froze as soon as my eyes fell upon him, and I stood there for several seconds, waiting for him to make a move. When nothing happened but a fresh round of cackling in my ears, I remembered where I was. Right: spooky fun house. There were bound to be a few surprises scattered about to give the guests a scare.

It was a pretty good one, too. I'd certainly been taken by it. Stepping forward, I moved closer to examine the prop. Unfortunately, that was the exact moment that my true mistake became clear. Whipping his arm forward, the man in the mask stabbed something sharp between my ribs. I yelped, more in shock than pain, and looked down to find a shard of broken mirror poking out from my sweater vest.

By the time I looked back up, the cat-masked assailant was gone. I tried to listen for him, but with all the music and sound effects blaring, it was impossible to tell what was real and what was just noise. I darted around the hall for a few moments, scouring for my attacker, but there was nothing to find. He'd apparently vanished after stabbing me.

With a grunt of annoyance, I grabbed the mirror shard and yanked it out. At least this time I knew I wasn't mistaken. There was definitely something else in the carnival with us.



4.

“Yup, that’s a stab wound all right. Or what’s left of one. Y’all heal faster than we do, and it doesn’t look like it did much damage to start with.” Bubba examined the slice in my chest, now looking like little more than an accidental scratch, then nodded, indicating I could lower my shirt.

Getting out of the fun house had been a quick affair. Rather than plunging further into the unknown and trying to find my way out, I’d simply doubled back the way I’d come. It was a tactic probably frowned upon when the ride was operating normally, but given the circumstances, I felt justified.

“Damn. This complicates things,” Richard said. “Fixing broken-down rides and repairing booths is one thing, but if some parahumans have made this place a home, then I’ve got to worry about the backlash from flushing them out, or if I’m even going to be able to. Depends on what they are, and if they’ve got allies. First things first though, we need to find Sally and Gideon. Fred, can you tell us anything else about the assailant? We can keep a lookout while we head their way.”

“Just that he was large—by normal standards, I mean—wore a cat mask, stabbed me, and then vanished.” I’d have loved to provide more information, but nothing more jumped to mind, no matter how much I wracked my brain. In the moment, I hadn’t realized the need to pay attention, and by the time I was smart enough to look for details, he was already gone.

Bubba rubbed his chin as I listed off the small bits of information I had. “Could be a ghost, maybe. Been here alone long enough, might have gone crazy and just started tryin’ to drive off intruders.”

“Then why haven’t any of the maintenance people had issues?” Richard pointed out. “We’re probably dealing with something nocturnal. Ghosts are stronger at night, true, but I can’t imagine that one strong enough to use a physical object wouldn’t have caused at least a little daytime trouble. Given our location, it might be a lost forest spirit that made this place its home. Plenty of those only manifest at night.”

“Um, didn’t you just say ghosts weren’t nocturnal?” I asked.

“Ghosts are a type of spirit, one that used to be human,” Richard explained. “But there’s a whole list of other spirit types out there. Most are so weak you’d never notice them if you weren’t looking. Every now and then, you come up against one with real power though, and those can be awfully territorial.”

Bubba yanked out his phone. “I can call Amy and Neil, have them here handling this place in no time.”

“Hang on. Right now, all we have is a best guess. I’d prefer to get my daughter to safety, regroup, and come back here during the day with some experts.” Richard took a few steps away from us, lifted his head up, and took

a long, deep sniff. I'd seen firsthand how good his tracking skills were, so I wasn't remotely surprised when he nodded down the fairway in a direction we hadn't been yet. "This place still stinks of cleaning chemicals and humans, but I can smell Gideon over there. Dragon is a hard musk to mistake for anything else."

We began jogging down the fairway, eschewing an outright run so that Richard could take his time following their trail. Bubba quickly fell into line next to me and began speaking loud enough to be heard while still staying quiet enough that he wouldn't break Richard's concentration. "If this is a spirit, then none of us can hurt it. You fight those usin' silver and magic, so we're shit out of luck on both fronts. Gideon can whup their asses no problem, so we're fine once we get to him. The upswing is that they won't be able to hurt us either."

"Tell that to my ruined vest," I muttered. Perhaps I was an extra bit miffed because it was yet another that needed replacing, and in the span of only a few weeks. I bought quality, so the things weren't cheap.

"I didn't say they couldn't annoy us." Bubba grinned, and we took a sharp turn as Richard suddenly changed direction.

He led us deeper into the carnival, bringing us to a midway where he began to slow down. Richard turned to and fro, squinting his eyes and wrinkling his nose. "How much cleaner did these people use? It stinks of chemicals all through here. I can barely follow Gideon's scent."

Richard came to a full stop, looking up and down the different paths leading through the midway. I took a test sniff as well and found that he was right. This whole area did have a heavy scent running through it. It smelled like they'd dumped a whole vat of chemicals on the ground. The lingering stink made detecting almost anything else impossible. Still, I tried my best, because with every passing second, I noticed Richard was getting a little less composed. Even if she was with Gideon, he worried about Sally constantly. I didn't know the whole story, but apparently she'd been the target of many a parahuman trying to turn the innocent girl into leverage. After Richard's position cost his wife her life, he'd been determined not to see the same happen to Sally. And that had led to his strange bargain with Gideon: giving the ancient dragon his blessing to wed his daughter when she was of proper age, but only if she agreed to marry him. The blessing was one thing, but Gideon had to win her heart on his own. It was an uncomfortable situation rooted in a culture that wasn't my own, so I tended to try not to think too hard about it. Richard was a man who loved his family, and when he'd been put in a hard position, he'd made the best call he could. That was the most any of us could do.

The sudden impact of Bubba's hand smacking me on the back got my attention away from futilely sniffing the air. Nodding over to one of the game

booths—the kind with undersized rings and oversized milk bottles—he drew my attention to movement. Someone was rising up from behind the booth. For a moment, I thought it was my attacker, but the body wasn't right. Plus, on closer inspection, this one was wearing a rabbit mask, albeit one as sun-bleached and dirt-stained as the cat version.

Now that I was paying attention, I saw more figures popping into view, rising up from different booths on the midway. They said nothing, their dirty, pale animal masks gazing eerily at us as they appeared. Could one spirit manifest in so many different forms? Or was this a collection of them, who'd all decided to make the empty carnival their home? I deeply wished I'd asked a few more questions before we starting running; information would have been extremely useful in this moment.

"Shit, that's a lot of 'em." Bubba took a step back, eyes darting between assailants. Even Richard had noticed now, although he looked far closer to furious than fearful. I could hear his heart hammering in his chest from several feet away. Bubba's as well, which was odd—he didn't seem *that* worked up. Then I noticed the next one, and it finally clicked.

No wonder I hadn't realized it before, with the blaring music inside the fun house and my general tendency to block out the cacophony of sounds vampire hearing dragged to my ears. Now that I'd noticed, there was no mistaking the noise for anything else though. It was a sound my senses were fine-tuned to recognize: heartbeats. The sound of precious blood being moved through a body.

"They've got heartbeats!" I yelled. "All of them have heartbeats. That means they aren't spirits, right?"

"That's right, Fred." Richard's expression had darkened. His fingers were flexing at his sides, the sharp nails already beginning to take on a more claw-like appearance in the flickering lights of the midway bulbs. "That means they have flesh and blood, both of which can be torn apart if they keep standing in our way."

"Looks like the Scooby approach didn't work." This voice was new, coming from a man in a dart-throwing booth. It was my cat-mask wearer, features still hidden as he finally spoke. "Too bad you boys didn't take the warning when you had the chance. Now, we've got to get messy."

Bubba cracked his knuckles, and Richard lowered his stance, winding up for a pounce. They were preparing to fight, and while the masked people had a numbers advantage, they were still in for a hell of a brawl. Unless it was an entire crew of fey or therians, I had a strong suspicion that Richard was about to rip a swath of blood through their ranks.

None of us were prepared for what came next, however. Instead of jumping out from the booths to fight us, the masked men all pulled out guns and took aim. We barely had time to register what was going on before Cat

Mask yelled an order to the rest of the gang. “Fire!”

And just like that, the world was suddenly drowned out in a sea of bullets.

5.

Prior to reconnecting with Krystal, my only real exposure to firearms was in the form of action films. However, after we began spending time together, I grew more accustomed to the presence of guns, mostly because she rarely left a room without one, and once Arch joined our group, they became even more commonplace. Rather than making me apathetic to the danger of guns, this fact only served to heighten my respect and awareness of their danger. Crazy as Krystal could be, she took firearm safety seriously, and being around her made it impossible for some of that attitude not to rub off on me.

That was why, in spite of knowing rationally that a mere bullet would be little more than an inconvenience to me, I still hit the ground as soon as the first shot rang through the air. Assuming safety in a shoot-out was ludicrous, vampire or not. To my surprise, Richard and Bubba were both lying on the concrete as well, dodging the initial volley that ripped through the air overhead.

“Huh, I wasn’t expectin’ this.” Bubba was close enough for me to hear him over the bullets cutting through the air, unlike Richard, who was stuck several feet away. He’d grabbed a plastic flask from somewhere in his pocket and had the cap halfway unscrewed. Something had stopped him from drinking whatever lay within, though. “It’s hard to get a good whiff with all the chemical stink in this place, but those don’t smell like silver bullets.”

He was right. While the scent of gunpowder was slowly choking out the chemical stench from the cleaners, there wasn’t so much as a single whiff of silver in the air. Not too surprising; no reasonable person would expect their hideout to be assaulted by a vampire and two were-creatures. Regular guns were more than enough to handle normal threats, especially this many of them, but they wouldn’t do much to the majority of parahumans. All of which begged the question: what were we dealing with? What sort of creature made a home in an abandoned carnival, tried to scare off intruders with stabbings, and then resorted to murder by impromptu firing squad?

I’m not especially proud of how long it took me to snap to this realization, but as I said earlier, spending so much time around other parahumans has a tendency to color the way one sees the world. “I think . . . I think they’re humans, Bubba. Just regular, run-of-the-mill humans. Or maybe I should say criminals? People who turned this place into a gang hideout.”

Bubba stared at me, then tilted his head back and took a long, careful breath. “Son of a bitch. That ain’t the smell of no damn cleaner. These assholes are cooking meth.”

While it took substantial willpower, I resisted asking exactly how Bubba could recognize that scent so readily as he craned his head up and shouted. “Richard! They’re just a bunch of meth-cookers using regular

bullets.”

“Seriously?” Richard looked to us, then over to one of the shooters who was wearing a bear mask. They were angling their firearms down, leaning over the top of the booth’s counters to get a line of sight on us, preparing to shoot while we were on the ground. “Oh. Well that makes this a lot easier.”

I can’t tell you exactly what motions Richard made, as his movements were too fast for even my eyes to follow. I just saw him press his hands to the ground, grin a mouthful of sharp teeth, and bolt forward into the booth where Bear Mask was taking aim. There was a brief scream from inside, which stopped without either warning or climax. The dirty mask was tossed over the counter, bouncing along the ground in plain view of the other attackers. Only now, it was almost completely covered in blood.

Instantly, the mood around us shifted. Guns that had been brazenly waved about were suddenly pulled in closer, and people standing out in the open shrank back. They were turning defensive on instinct, having just seen something unnatural, bordering on impossible. Right now, their understanding of what was real was at war with the sight before their eyes. This wasn’t the way things were supposed to go, and they knew it. If they hadn’t just tried to kill us, I probably would have felt genuinely bad for them.

When Richard rose back into view, his mouth was smeared in blood, a red circle around rows of teeth too big and sharp for any human. Tufts of fur ran down his face and arms, down to hands which ended in long, serrated claws stained vermillion. As Bubba rose from the ground next to me, I kept staring. Being around Richard the father and friend—the kind, oversized man I was used to—it was easy to forget just how terrifying he truly was when the situation demanded it. Richard was an alpha therian who’d earned and held his position at the top of his tribe through no one’s strength but his own. It wasn’t the first time his fangs and claws had been coated in blood, nor did I have any illusions it would be the last. Now, I really *did* feel sorry for our assailants.

One of the criminals in a rabbit mask started to tilt their gun toward him, and Richard let out a roar that made the man shriek and draw back. Even if he consciously still thought he could win, his instincts knew to draw back from the sound of an angry lion. The rest cowered, save for Cat Mask, who seemed to be watching it all unfold warily. He knew the situation was dangerous; however, he’d yet to give in to his fear. I got to my feet next to Bubba, keeping my eye on him. No need to take pointless chances and let him surprise us.

“You poor, stupid bastards.” Richard’s voice was deep and gruff, closer to animal than human. His whole body was tense, poised to strike at a moment’s provocation. “You really have no idea who you’ve fucked with

tonight. I'll give you one chance, and one chance only. Toss your guns into the midway and lay down on the counters. We're going to call . . . I guess they'd be our version of the police, and they'll turn you over to the regular cops. Eventually. If anyone doesn't like that proposal, then feel free to try something." His tongue, now inhumanly long, stretched out and licked the blood from around his mouth.

"I'm still plenty hungry enough for the rest of you."

The sound of metal hitting concrete filled the air as guns clattered down in the midway. I knew enough to be aware that dropping a firearm didn't actually discharge it, yet I still winced a little every time one landed. Some ideas from movies are harder to root out than others. While the guns rained to the ground, I kept my eye on Cat Mask, noticing he'd yet to surrender his. After a moment, I realized that his face was turned in my direction as well. Right . . . he thought he'd stabbed me. Well, I mean he *had* stabbed me, but he'd expected me to stay stabbed. Although I could never be as terrifying as Richard, I could still make sure this man knew he was dealing with beings outside his realm of understanding. With a wide smile showing off my fangs, I carefully lifted my shirt and sweater vest, displaying the now completely healed and unblemished skin.

"Monsters." The voice was less composed than the body language, shaky terror replacing the authority he'd spoken with before. "No, there's no such thing as monsters." Cat Mask lifted his gun, unsteady as his hand was, and pointed it at me. "We just made a bad batch, guys. That's all this is. We're seeing shit. They noticed, and they're bluffing us."

"I seriously urge you to take us up on the chance to surrender." Bubba's voice was surprisingly gentle, given the situation. I noticed that he'd tucked his plastic flask out of sight once more. "This is already not endin' well for any of you, but life is long. One day, you might turn yourself around and discover some happiness in the world. Fire that gun, and you ain't never gettin' the chance to find out."

They were sound words of advice, and as Cat Mask kept his gun trained on me, I dearly hoped he'd listen to them. If he pulled that trigger, I'd be fine, but Richard would undoubtedly be on him before the recoil was finished. Cat Mask didn't understand that the person he was really holding the gun on was himself. We stood like that, silent, waiting to see what choice he made. Then a new voice rang out, shattering the silence and changing the situation entirely.

"Daddy?"

All eyes moved to the edge of the midway. Sally was standing there, looking over at her father with worry and confusion. And unfortunately, I do mean *all* eyes, including those of Cat Mask, who swung both his attention and his weapon in her direction.

6.

All of us were moving, dashing, as fast as we could. I dimly heard the tear of canvas and snap of wood as Richard plowed through the booth he was in without being slowed by even an instant. There was no discussion or thought, only a mad race to reach Cat Mask before his arm finished its journey. While it's true that—and upon looking back, it's easy to realize that his movements may have been reactionary—there was no guarantee he planned to shoot, and even if he had, Sally was a therian as well. But none of that entered my, and I presume the others' minds at the time. The only thing we understood or saw was a gun moving in the direction of a child, and we moved our bodies with all we had to stop it.

None of us were fast enough, however, and that includes Cat Mask. The weapon's muzzle was just approaching Sally's general direction when it vanished, along with Cat Mask's hand and a big chunk of his forearm. I heard a *thud* from behind the midway, one that I had a firm guess was the gun and limb in question landing, and then Gideon appeared.

He stood between Sally and Cat Mask, the barest flecks of blood visible on his nails. I was a little surprised the criminal wasn't screaming in pain, and then I noticed that I couldn't actually hear any noise coming from the booth he was in, even as he grabbed his stump of an arm and stomped about. Of course. Gideon was magically silencing him for the same reason he'd tossed the arm out of sight. He didn't want Sally to see or hear such things.

"You *dare* point a weapon at her? Make no mistake, pitiful creature, I have woven so many spells and protections around her that even another dragon would struggle to do her harm, yet for you to even attempt such a thing is a dire insult. An insult to me, which is bad, and to *her*, which is infinitely worse."

Unlike Richard, Gideon wasn't trying to be scary. He was calm, detached even, looking at Cat Mask and the other criminals as if they were no more concern than garbage in his path. In a way, that was much more terrifying than Richard's performance. I knew too well that Gideon could kill everyone in this carnival—hell, everyone in the *state*—with little effort and even less remorse. The only person I'd seen him show any concern or care for was Sally, and they'd just turned a gun on her. In that moment, I knew that Cat Mask had just gotten his entire gang killed. Richard might have been willing to let them be turned over to the cops, but Gideon wasn't nearly so kind-hearted.

As it turned out though, someone else was.

"Gideon, no." Sally reached out and grabbed him by the arm, yanking him back over in her direction. There was a surprising amount of



authority in her voice; it was easy to see that she was indeed her father's daughter. "They didn't hurt me. Daddy and Bubba and Fred look okay, too. No blood. Not tonight. Don't ruin the carnival."

Gideon met her eyes, nodding over to the booth where Cat Mask was still silently stomping about. "That man would have happily done harm to you, your father, and his servants. The air reeks of bullets and gun smoke; that was the noise we heard earlier. They are bad people, Sally."

She crossed her arms and stared him down, refusing to budge an inch on the issue. "Everyone has good in them. No blood, Gideon. If you do, I won't . . . I won't talk to you or play with you for a whole week."

I genuinely had no idea what reaction to expect from such an ultimatum, but to my surprise, the ancient dragon tilted his head back and let out a genuine laugh. He was smiling as he finished, and he reached over, bringing Sally in close. Gently, he rested his forehead against hers, though his few extra inches of height meant he was leaning slightly to do so.

"My *leardrun*, you truly are too kind-hearted for this detestable world. But I cannot abide such punishment, so I have no choice in the matter. As you desire, no blood." His eyes darted down to the crimson stain on his nails. "No more blood, anyway. Yet these are still criminals. Will you at least permit me to restrain them until the agents arrive?"

"You won't hurt them?" Sally asked.

"Not so much as a scratch or a bruise. Words, only words, with perhaps a bit of magic to ensure my orders are truly heard. You have my promise." Gideon lifted his head up and slowly moved away from Sally. Once they were parted, he turned to the midway, where a gang of criminals in dirty animals masks looked like they didn't know if they should bolt, void their bladders, or beg for mercy. There really wasn't a wrong option in the situation: none of it would have mattered to Gideon. His punishment for their sins would be carried out no matter what.

"Humans. Pitiful, useless humans with lives as short as the flicker of a candle, be at ease. You will survive to see another sunrise. Her mercy has spared your pointless lives, so gather the few years remaining to you and clutch them close. They are a gift, given to you in spite of what you've done here. Use them well, greet every morning with the knowledge that your days were meant to end tonight, here in this battered old carnival."

Gideon had moved to the center of the midway, every eye upon him. I wasn't sure I could have looked away, even if I wanted to. His lavender irises were shining brightly, too brightly, and occasionally, I would catch glimpses of his shadow from the poorly burning bulbs of the carnival. Sometimes, it was the shadow of a child, but sometimes, often for only the span of a blink, it was something else. Something vast, and old, that made my eyes ache to look upon for even less than a heartbeat. From the booths, I

could hear tears and sniffing. Behind those masks, the criminals were weeping. Not in joy; their hearts were racing much too fast. It was more like they were staring death in the eye, crying in terror at their utter helplessness. And that was the moment I understood that we were only getting part of the show. The humans were experiencing a speech that was worlds more potent, and horrifying.

“But with that gratitude, you should also greet each day fearfully.” Gideon was getting louder, his eyes brighter. I couldn’t look away, yet it hurt every second I watched him. “Tonight, you have learned the truth of the world. You now know why your ancestors flocked to the first fire, trying so hard to fend back the darkness. For it is not empty shadows as you’ve trained yourself to believe. You have regained the truth that your kind has fought so hard to deny: there are monsters in the darkness, waiting for the moment that you step away from the light. Remember that, when your time in cells is over and you’re tempted to slink back to another shaded hole like this one. Remember that there are worse things than humans who have stepped off the righteous path. Remember the nightmares who drove your kind toward the light in the first place. And remember me, above all else. Remember the beast with gnashing jaws and scaly hide, who rules over these shadowlands, devouring lesser nightmares. I will be watching, waiting, to see if you dirty her kindness with more wicked acts. And if you do, there is no force that can save you, pitiful, worthless humans.”

Gideon paused, letting a moment of silence wash over us all. He was smiling again, though this was nothing like the kind grin he’d shown Sally. Once, for a brief time, Gideon and I had been magically connected, and perhaps because of that, I could see too much in his smile. Millennia of blood, battle, war, pain, loss, and suffering, all of which he’d borne. There was no hubris in his words. He was a nearly unstoppable being, bound only by his pride and promises. As well as a single friendship to a small therian child.

“No one will help you. No one will save you. Not your drugs, not your guns, not your gods. For I am a force beyond your comprehension. I am a killer, a ruler, a king of these shadowed lands. And my name is *dragon*.”

At the last word, something in the air seemed to snap. It was like a brief wave of air washing over us, and when it was done, the spell was broken. Broken for the parahumans, anyway. Everyone wearing a mask had fallen to the ground, clutching themselves—some praying, some still weeping, some just babbling incoherently. Gideon had kept his word, though. None of them, aside from Cat Mask, had so much as a single scratch.

“Someone call the agents to clean these messes up,” Gideon commanded. His eyes, shadow, and voice were all mercifully back to normal. “I promised Sally that we would take a ride on the carousel.”

7.

The relationship between traditional law enforcement personnel and agents is a strange one. While the agents have higher clearances and the authority to get away with hand-waving off very reasonable questions from officers, the normal cops still always seems to know that something is off when they deal with one. That said, police officers are also generally experienced enough to see the difference between a fight they want to pick, and an easy win that it's better to just roll with.

Finding an entire gang of meth dealers ready and willing to surrender as soon as they saw flashing lights was just that sort of win. In the days to come, we'd learn that these people were originally employees of the maintenance company hired to keep the place up. One of them, Cat Mask, had seen the opportunity in a remote location with almost no oversight. He recruited some of his fellow workers and crooks, set up shop, and suddenly the carnival wasn't quite so abandoned anymore. As an added boon, Lonnie's grandfather had apparently done some bootlegging along with his moonshine business. That, or there was some other reason for hidden tunnels running between the attractions. The honeycomb of routes beneath the grounds allowed the meth dealers to vanish when the maintenance workers came through for their monthly cleaning. It was an ideal set-up, until a few parahumans came sniffing around looking to restore the place.

I sat on the lowered tailgate of Bubba's truck, watching as Krystal barked orders at several overworked and visibly annoyed officers. The night had taken such a strange turn. All I'd wanted was an evening out, getting my mind off my vacant assistant position. Which, to be fair, I hadn't really dwelt on since we arrived. But still . . . I'd been enjoying the work until things went crazy. This had been planned as a simple, normal gig. Sure, the owner was a therian, but a carnival was a carnival. It wasn't supposed to end in a gunfight. Staring at the once again closed gates, part of me wondered if it was always going to be like this. Were my days of routine work behind me for good? Sure, I liked the occasional burst of excitement; yet I'd also really treasured the straightforward task of normal accounting work. It seemed like the deeper I got into the parahuman world, the fewer and further between the mundane moments became. And as a freelance accountant for the Agency, I was in pretty damn deep by this point.

From behind a cop car, Gideon and Sally emerged. They'd finished up on the carousel before the police arrived and were now strolling about killing time while Richard finished giving a statement. Bubba and I had completed our conversations more quickly, since we were just hired help, while he needed to explain his presence here. It was strange to watch the children—well, one child and one dragon—knowing what Gideon had done

to those people. I had tried to talk to a few of the crooks while we waited for Krystal, and none had let out more than gibberish and whimpering. They'd been broken on a fundamental level. Maybe they'd improve with time, but I doubted they'd ever truly recover. And that had been Gideon showing mercy. Even though I was a vampire, I'd still grown up human, with human ideals and morality instilled in me. I sometimes forgot that such wasn't the case with all supernatural creatures. They had their own ideas of right and wrong. Ideas I wasn't sure I ever wanted to fully understand.

The truck sank down as Bubba took a seat next to me on the open tailgate. He followed my eyes, staring at Gideon and Sally as they chatted with an officer who did her best to keep them from paying attention to the parade of criminals being marched to cars. Bless that woman's heart, she was trying to protect them from understanding what had happened. She had no idea that one of the children she wanted to shield was the very thing those hardened criminals were scared witless of.

"Why do I have a feeling there wasn't bourbon or vodka in that flask of yours?" I'm not sure where those words came from; I certainly hadn't planned on confronting Bubba about what I'd seen. But the moment I opened my mouth, that was what came out. Perhaps some part of me was dwelling on the night Amy had accidentally turned Bubba into a giant, flame-coated version of himself, which Lillian and I had needed to punch down so he could be cured.

"Amy's a determined gal. She ain't one to let a single failed experiment put her off course." At least he wasn't trying to deny it or play games. Dealing with Bubba was refreshing; he was one of the few people in my life who tended to shoot straight by habit.

"So that stuff would have done what? Turned you into Nightmare Bubba two-point-oh?"

"Nah, we passed that a long time ago. I think this is version eight or nine, but Amy's the one who keeps track of that." Reaching to his pocket, he tapped the top of the flask gently. "And it's a hell of lot better than the one you saw. I don't lose control anymore. Trust me, Fred, I wouldn't have even considered drinking the stuff around my friends if it wasn't safe. Especially with Sally on the scene."

I believed him. Bubba wasn't the sort of man to take careless risks with others' lives. I only wished he showed the same amount of concern for himself. "That's all well and good, but I don't see why you need it in the first place. You're plenty strong and tough on your own. And you help Richard as an assistant, not a mercenary. Why do you need more power so badly that you're willing to go to these sorts of lengths?"

Bubba laid his hand on the top of his truck bed, using it as an armrest. "First off, if you think working for the head therian of a tribe doesn't involve

busting some heads, then you don't know jack about the job. But yeah, I can deal with most of that on my own. I grew up a runt, and that means I learned to handle myself early on. The potion is because . . ." He paused, rubbing his face and adjusting his ballcap.

"Damn it, Fred, I can't rightly explain this kind of shit to you. Since you got turned, you've always had more power than you needed. A little dollop of vampire strength is more than enough to get you through a life of crunching numbers. You don't know what it's like to be around people outside your weight class every day, dragons and mages and alpha therians who tolerate you, maybe even like you, but ain't your peers. Imagine you spent all your time around accountants with much higher educations and certifications than you've got, and they let you pitch in on the little stuff, but left you behind whenever a big case came in. Would you accept that? Be happy just to be hanging around? Or would you start upping your own education in the hopes of one day standing alongside them?"

"I guess I don't know," I admitted. It was strange. Though I tended to think of Bubba as vastly more experienced and powerful than me, the truth was that, in the therian world, his small shifted form did make him weak. Weaker than he should have been, at any rate. While I'd been mentally lumping him in with the likes of Richard, in truth, Bubba was probably closer in power to me than the head of the Winslow therians. "I'll try not to judge, Bubba. This is your life, and if Amy is the one making the potions, then at least I know she'll be safe. Just promise me you'll be careful going down this road. You're not our friend, any of us, because of your strength. You're our friend because you're you. And I think we'd rather have you be human than lose you entirely."

"Thanks. I appreciate . . . it means a lot." Bubba seemed to falter, his long speech having used up most of his words for the evening.

"Also, if you're trying to catch up to others, aim for Richard, not Gideon. I don't even want to imagine what kind of potion Amy would need to whip up to put us on his level."

"If that recipe existed, I think all the dragons would band together to destroy it," Bubba said. "They're not big on competition."

We looked over to Gideon and Sally again, the latter of whom was now wearing the policewoman's hat. "Do you know what *leardrun* means? I heard him call Sally that, but I've got no clue what language that even is."

Bubba nodded, albeit slowly. "It's draconic, doesn't have a perfect translation to any other language. The closest we'd get on the words is 'dear one,' but that can't really encompass the meaning. It's a word they use for a being they prize above all others, beyond life itself. There's no direct relationship implied. It can be used between friends, siblings, and spouses freely. What matters is the context of it, that the word is a pledge to shelter,

aid, and protect their dear one in all situations, regardless of the cost. Dragons take their words, and their promises, very seriously.”

That more or less fit with what I’d guessed the meaning would be, although I’d underestimated the depth of the sentiment. To his credit, whatever else could be said of Gideon, I had always seen him treat Sally just as the word implied. There were legends of kings pleading with dragons lesser than he, only for their words to fall on deaf ears, but Sally had held Gideon back with only a simple demand.

“Do you think he loves her?” It was another question I hadn’t intended to ask, yet it popped out all the same.

“I don’t know if dragons have the same concept of love as we do,” Bubba replied. “I don’t know if Gideon is even capable of love. But I know that he’s devoted to her. He reshaped himself and lived as a child solely so that she would grow up with a friend and guardian at her side.” Bubba paused again, though this time, it wasn’t lack of words that stalled his tongue. He’d grown nervous at the topic, which was fair with Gideon so close; it would be foolish to assume he couldn’t hear us. “Fred, do you know what Sally is?”

“Not all the details, but . . .” I turned to him, not wishing to speak this out loud even if it wouldn’t fool Gideon. This was more for the sake of discretion; some things were not to be uttered in public regardless of circumstances. Carefully, I mouthed the word “Tiamat” before turning away. Gideon had explained part of the situation to me once, and while I didn’t have all the details of what made Sally into one, I knew that a tiamat was a being who could birth dragons, yet wasn’t subject to their issues with low conception rates. Tiamats were named after a dragon mother-goddess for that reason. “I don’t understand everything that comes with that, but that makes her special, right?”

“More than special. Crucial. If one only comes every thousand years, it’s a miracle. They need her, and he knows that. That’s why Gideon prizes her above even his own life. He’s just one dragon. Sally is vital to their entire species.”

“She’s just a kid.” I watched as Sally gave the woman back her hat, and for an instant, I saw Gideon’s gaze turn to us. There was no threat in his eyes, no smile promising bloodshed. He didn’t care that we were talking about them. He probably barely even cared that we existed. The only one he gave a damn about was standing at his side.

“For now. One day, she’ll grow up, and when that happens, a lot of dragons are going to try and make demands of her. If nothin’ else, I’m glad she’s got one in her corner. Gideon is dangerous, powerful, and ain’t got much regard for human life. But he’s promised to protect her, and I’ve never seen him break his word. Whatever is waiting for Sally on the other side of adulthood, at least Gideon will make sure she meets it on her terms. That’s

more than the rest of us would be able to do for her.”

We were interrupted as Richard made his way over, finally released from police questioning. “Well, this whole thing turned into a pain in the ass. So help me, if I find out Lonnie had any idea of this, I’m going to knock his oversized teeth out.”

“Lonnie is a wererat. They ain’t known for their guts, and I sure as shit don’t expect he planned on a group of drugged-out crooks bringing you down,” Bubba said.

“All the same, I think I’m going to pass on this investment opportunity. Sorry to drag you both out here for nothing other than a shootout.”

My eyes finally left Gideon and Sally, turning once more to the gate of the carnival. “Actually, Richard, you should reconsider that.”

Richard looked at me like I’d just suggested he shave off his golden locks and start wearing a bright blue wig. “You’re joking. The place is a crime scene.”

“True, but eventually, it will be cleaned up,” I said. “And when that happens, you’ve got a carnival in surprisingly good shape that can be restored at a reasonable cost. But even better, you have a network of tunnels running underneath. With a little re-tooling of the rides, some shading and sun-proofing, along with bigger seats, you could make a carnival that was parahuman-friendly. You’ll tremendously expand your customer base. Plus, during October, let them visit in their natural states and poof: instant haunted park the likes of which no one else can match. There’s money to be made here, Richard. Bring in some experts to do a serious assessment and get real numbers, but I’m sure they’ll back me up on the profit potential. I might even throw in some cash of my own, if you’re open to other investors.”

He followed my eyes, staring past the gate to the worn-down carnival inside. Only now, he was seeing what it could be, instead of what it was. “If I was part-owner of this place, I could close it off occasionally so that Sally could come through without Gideon needing to kill anyone.”

“Bring along your friends and loyal employees, turn the whole thing into a morale-building event,” I added.

“All right, Fred, you’ve got me interested again. I’ll hire some pros to figure out what it will cost to turn this place around, then see if it’s worth the investment. You can stay in the loop, too, if you were serious about buying a stake.” Richard winced as soon as the word was out of his mouth. “Sorry, poor choice of phrase.”

I waved him off. “Don’t worry about it. And I’m definitely interested. It’s time to diversify my portfolio anyway, and I like the idea of putting cash into something that makes our town a little better.”

After the night we’d been through and what I’d seen Gideon do,

maybe it was only a small bit of good to try and bring a place of fun and entertainment back to town. But it would still be some amount of positivity, and at that point, I was willing to take whatever I could get.



## **A Negotiation at the Table**

1.

“Shirts, slacks, sweater vests, socks and sundries, shoes, my flask of blood, some backup blood in case we get trapped in a time loop, laptop, snake-bite kit, flashlight, rope, bottle of water, flare guns, a compass, a lock pick set, and a ten-pack of batteries. What do you think?”

Krystal stared at me from her seat next to the bed, occasionally peeking over the side of my suitcase to see if the items I was listing were really in there. “I think it sounds like you’re packing for a weekend at some sort of camping sex resort, not hanging out with a couple of mages. Snake-bite kit and a flashlight? Freddy, vampires don’t get poisoned by something as mundane as snakes, and you have perfect darkvision.”

“For now, I do. One random spell and for all we know: poof! Suddenly I’m as blind as a human in the shadows.”

“Okay, and the lock pick set? I’m pretty sure you have no idea how to use one of these,” Krystal said, reaching over and snapping it up from within the bag.

“True, but I have access to the internet, tutorial videos, and depending on what’s happening, I might be highly motivated.” I grabbed the lock pick set back and tossed it into my suitcase, along with the other odd accoutrements for the trip.

In all honestly, I knew Krystal was right and I was being a touch ridiculous, but I felt as though there was some merit to my attitude. Mages were one of the aspects of the parahuman world I understood the least. Therians and vampires, even demons and dragons, I could wrap my head around. Different species, the evolution of strange viruses or creatures that spawned in unique environments—there was a path to understanding those for one as rooted in a life of normalcy as me. But magic, and those who wielded it, was a whole other story. The mere idea that a few drops of herbs and spoken words could conjure power to defy the laws of nature was just a little too much. It hadn’t really been that bad at first. I considered what Amy did just exceptional use of natural plants and a bit of off-brand science. But then I’d spent several days in a time-bubble conjured by a pair of bickering mages: the Clover twins. That was when I’d first started to get a taste of just how far outside the bounds of reality magic was able to operate. I’d walked away more than happy to never get too involved with the practice of magic again.

And yet now I was going to meet a grand mage, which was apparently similar to, yet quite distinct from, an archmage. Amy had stopped by earlier that day to let me know that the head of her district—yes, it seems mages sorted themselves by districts in their hierarchy; news to me as well—had requested a meeting with me. Not as myself, mind you, a humble

accountant able to help streamline most businesses. No, the grand mage was calling on me as the head of the House of Fred, one that Amy had joined in a show of solidarity last year. I'd known even then that there would be a price to pay for such things, so there was no chance I could, or would, shirk the duty. I just wished I had a better idea of what to pack.

"You sure you don't want me to tag along? There's bound to be some precedence we can use. I bet Arch will be able to think of something," Krystal offered.

Tempting as it was, I shook my head to the negative. "The grand mage requested a closed meeting, just me and Amy. This isn't Agency business; I don't have a good reason to bring an agent along for backup. Trust me, if I could think of a way to take you with me without starting us off on a bad foot, I'd use it in a heartbeat."

Krystal grinned, a touch of mischief in her smile. "I do make a great diplomacy asset. Like a hammer you can bust out and smash through a table."

"There is that, yes, but mostly I'd just like the opportunity to spend some time together. It feels like we've both been doing nothing but traveling over the past few weeks." To be fair, that had somewhat always been the case. It was in the nature of Krystal's job as an agent—she went where the trouble was. Only now, between taking on Agency work, coping with being down an assistant, and pitching in to help Richard with the carnival whenever I could, my own hours were at a premium as well. I'd been hoping to schedule a break over the weekend; however, it seemed that life had other plans.

Slowly, Krystal made her way around the bed and draped her arms over my shoulders. "I've missed you, too. Maybe once you wrap this up, I'll put in for some vacation time. If you work ahead and let Lillian handle the little stuff, I bet you could swing a long weekend. We could head down to Boarback, have a nice trip exploring the town, away from all the craziness."

"Personally, I wouldn't say no to a wine-tasting tour in Napa, or maybe a nice ski-cottage, but the details are up to you. All that matters to me is that we make some time for one another." I kissed her—not to drive the point home, but because she was nearby and I loved her. It had taken a lot of strange events in my life, up to and including a slight death, but I'd finally reached a point where I was comfortable in a relationship with someone. That wasn't something I planned to let slip away by taking it for granted.

"I'll put out some feelers to see what kind of dates I can get," Krystal said. "In the meantime, you need to finish packing. I bet there's a portable generator or set of drill bits you can still fit in your suitcase. Never know when you'll need those."

A crisp knock on the bedroom door dispelled our romantic mood. "Come in," I yelled. The door didn't open; however, Charlotte was standing in front of us a moment later, appearing in her usual form. It had taken a few

tries and one powerpoint presentation, but she'd finally understood that, even if we knew she could see everything that happened within her walls, it was still easier for us all if she knocked before appearing in a room. It was a small illusion done for the sake of formality, yet it made a big difference in overall comfort. If we could delude ourselves into thinking we had privacy, that was enough.

"Fred, you requested notification when Amy had returned. She has arrived in the parking lot. At least, I assume the long golden Humvee limousine is hers. I'd have told you sooner, but I needed to look up what sort of vehicle it was online. Humans have taken their transportation in . . . curious directions."

It wasn't what I'd expected Amy to arrive in, but as a rule, I tried never to expect anything with Amy. She was a little too out there. Whatever I tried to predict was invariably wrong, so instead, I just resigned myself to always being surprised. Even with that attitude, my dismay over the vehicle in question must have shown on my face.

"Word to the wise, Freddy: Amy is a little more down-to-earth than most mages. You should be braced for more ostentatiousness than I think you're expecting." Krystal patted me, half with love and half with amusement, on the back. "A big-ass limo is not going to be the weirdest thing you see."

"So long as it has a driver and avoids the sun, I'll be fine," I assured her. "Amy is part of my parahuman clan. I'll be sure to represent her well."

"Just be you," Krystal told me. "Or a version of you that's thirty percent less skittish. And whatever happens, roll with it. Spell-casters love keeping normal folk off-balance. Don't try to question things too deeply. Accept the reality you have to work with, and power through."

"The more you talk, the more I regret not finding a way to bring you along." I finished packing my suitcase and zipped it up, hefting it off the bed easily. "Charlotte, you were constructed by mages. Is there any advice you'd like to offer?"

She hesitated, as she always did when discussion of her previous tenants surfaced. If I'd been less hurried and more considerate, I would have realized the question might be too personal. Just as I was about to apologize and retract the inquiry, however, Charlotte answered.

"Mages are humans at their core. Humans whose bodies are altered by constant exposure to magic, and who age at a decelerated rate, but still humans. They enjoy and indulge in the culture of other humans, but because of their dedication to the craft and their unique relationship with time, it's not uncommon for a higher-ranked mage to get . . . stuck, for lack of a better term, during whatever culture was predominant the last time they dealt with normal humans. Case in point: of my builders, one favored fashions from the

revolutionary war, one enjoyed Victorian sensibilities, and one embraced the simple rustic look of farmers. So if you meet people who seem a bit out of place, as Krystal already encouraged you, just roll with it. And keep in mind that a mage's power is not like a vampire's bite: it is transferred through knowledge and practice, not a simple swapping of blood. Every mage you meet is capable and dangerous, if they wish to be."

Part of me really wanted to ask about the clothing thing; just how long did mages live past normal human lives? Unfortunately, time wasn't on my side, and I already felt like I'd pried deeper than was respectful into Charlotte's past. I nodded my head in thanks, gave Krystal a quick peck as a goodbye, and headed down the stairs with my suitcase in hand.

Sure enough, waiting out in the parking lot was a huge, golden Humvee limo. I could smell the exhaust before the front door was even open, and as I darted across the parking lot, I wondered how much of the tank had been burned off simply waiting for me to finish packing. Making my way to the back, I pulled open the door to find Amy already seated, her normally brown hair glowing a soft cerulean and a glass of champagne, clearly poured from the included bar, in her hand. She offered it to me as I took a seat, though I declined.

"Before you say anything, this wasn't my idea." Amy took a long drink from the glass I'd refused, quickly finished it off, and poured herself another. "Cyndi promised to handle transportation, since she was calling the meeting, and this is what showed up. I think she might want to impress you."

"It is quite the overt display of—hang on, did you say the grand mage I'm meeting is named Cyndi?" Of all the things to get hung up on, I'll admit it was an odd one, but that was what leapt out at me in the moment. "Sorry, I suppose I expected something grander, like Merlin or Gandalf—"

"Or Amy? Or Neil?" She chuckled under her breath as she took another drink of champagne. "We start off as humans, remember. A few take new names when they get to new ranks, but it's a lot of pain in the ass for very little gain. Get that hokey D&D shit out of your head, otherwise you're going to be in for a really tiring trip."

"Speaking of Neil, where is your apprentice tonight?" I asked. Neil was, technically, a part of my clan as well, so if this concerned Amy, it stood to reason he might need to be present.

"As far from this shit as I can keep him." Amy's relaxed expression hardened for a brief moment before fading away in the calming glow of her hair. "Dealing with the kinds of mages who care about status and rank is the sort of thing he needs to be ready for. For as long as I can swing it, he stays away from the politics of this job."

I settled in, placing my suitcase to my side and buckling my seatbelt as the massive vehicle lurched into motion. "Interesting. I never expected

riages to have much in the way of politics.”

With a grim stare, Amy grabbed the champagne bottle and topped her glass off once more. “Then you’d better brace for a lot of surprises, Fred. Otherwise, we’ll both end up floating on shit creek.”

2.

Our drive was a surprisingly brief one. The limo got onto the highway for approximately forty-five minutes—enough time for me to mentally go through nine scenarios in which I said the wrong thing and got us all killed—before turning off on an exit that led to a small farm-road. Twenty more minutes of driving through trees and dirt roads, some of which I was legitimately certain would be too tough for the limo to navigate, eventually led us to a faded red barn in the middle of a field. The doors unlocked as we arrived, and Amy immediately began to exit, so I followed her lead. As I grabbed my suitcase, I tried very hard not to dwell on the fact that this was exactly the sort of place where it would be easy to kill us and destroy our bodies.

The unseen driver kept the lights of our limo on as we disembarked, making sure the barn's front doors were well illuminated. Hardly a subtle hint, but at least we didn't have to waste time guessing where we'd be headed. Amy took the lead; her small backpack (that I knew held more than it appeared to) was tossed over her shoulder as she trekked through the field without hesitation. It was a strange sight, and not just because we were in the backend of nowhere during the middle of the night. Among the huge bodies and personalities of our friends, Amy often tended to slide into the background. She seemed happy there—part of the action, yet away from its center, around the warm glow of friends without always needing to be engaged. However, that didn't mean Amy wasn't a brilliant, capable person in her own right. I'd heard many a time from different sources how highly regarded her work was considered, and as I watched her plow ahead to the mysterious barn without so much as losing a step, I could see the sort of steadfast determination that might account for such a reputation.

The door opened before Amy arrived, albeit only by a few seconds. It slid itself ajar, revealing an empty barn, which I should have expected, yet which still caught me off guard. Amy wasn't put off in the slightest. She kept right on walking, passing the forgotten hay bales and empty pens, keeping on track for a door near the back of the barn. I missed it the first time I scanned the room; in fact, even when Amy stepped right next to it, I had to squint and focus to notice the cream-colored door. Unlike the rest of this place, it was clearly new, with golden symbols painted all along the edges and around the knob. Amy paused for the first time since leaving the limo, looking over her shoulder to me.

"I'm pretty sure you've already figured this out, but the door isn't just going to lead us out of the barn. I don't know where we're going, mind you; only that it won't be here. Cyndi can be a bit distrustful at times, so she tends to prepare all her meetings in secure locations. Anchoring doorways at

meeting points is the easiest way to get people there without having them know where they're going."

"Hang on. So we're going to teleport?" You'd think after being stuck outside time this wouldn't have seemed like so big of deal, but it was still something I'd yet to encounter. Even Krystal and Arch took planes to get around, so if teleportation existed, I'd assumed the Agency would use it.

"Technically, no. It's more like space has been folded over on itself inside the small span of this door. We're going to step over all the space between and arrive at the destination instantly. Very different from pure teleportation, and please don't ask me to explain it in more detail than that. The whole thing is highly theoretical. Doing the spell requires an expertise in conjuration, and setting it in a door is only an option for those with a subspecialty in enchanting. Spatial rearrangement is a talent of Cyndi's though, so you don't need to worry about anything going wrong in transport."

I actually hadn't even considered the idea until Amy mentioned it. I'd just been wrapping my head around the idea of teleportation; it hadn't yet occurred to me that the fact the spell existed didn't mean it would necessarily go perfectly. I'd seen the trial-and-error nature of magic firsthand during my friendship with Amy, and none of that had involved hurling people across rifts in space. Suddenly, I could understand why the Agency might prefer to stick with planes.

Given enough time, I'd have worked myself into quite a panic, which was perhaps why Amy didn't give me the chance. She pulled open the door, revealing a white hallway, and stepped through. I followed quickly, afraid that without her around, I might never find the door again after it closed. My movements were so quick that before I even noticed, I'd passed through the doorway. It was completely painless, not so much as even a tingle or a buzz in the ears as I literally stepped across unknown space to arrive at my new destination.

It was sunny. I noticed that right away, my survival instincts kicking into full gear as I held up the suitcase to try and shield myself from the glowing rays. After a few seconds of hiding, I noticed that the bits of me that had touched the light were neither cooked nor smoking, so I lowered my bag to take a better look. All of the sunlight was coming through glass, and I could make out a few runes engraved on every pane. Enchanted glass to keep the sunlight from hurting vampires, clearly, though this was a step above what I'd seen before. Generally, the stuff always came with at least some amount of tinting, but these panes were so clear it was like I was looking at the sky. I stood there, numb to the rest of my surroundings, as I looked up at the sun. How long had it been since I saw it like this? My eyes watered, perhaps from the bright light, more likely from sentiment, though I wiped them and remembered myself before I lost all sense of composure. I'd come to do a job,



and I couldn't afford distractions, no matter how beautiful they were.

When I'd first looked through the door—a door I turned around and realized was no long present—I'd taken the white hallway to look sterile. And compared to a filthy, abandoned night barn, it had seemed that way. But these weren't the white halls of a hospital or government building. No, these were white because they were meant to glow in the sun which came in from all angles, lighting the room and the beautiful turquoise water only steps away. We were at a beach house—a spacious and modern one at that. Had they always used a glass that was vampire friendly, or was it retrofitted just for this meeting? It was a strong message, if they'd done it intentionally. An olive branch to give me something I'd thought forever lost, but also a threat to remind me how vulnerable I was here.

Following the hallway, I turned to find myself in a vast, stainless steel kitchen. In all my excitement about the sunshine coming in from the ceiling, I hadn't noticed the music playing in the background, but now that I'd made the turn, it was impossible to ignore. While the tune was one I couldn't quite place, the amount of synthesizer and general style made it abundantly obvious that this was music from the eighties. For a second, I wondered if I'd somehow jumped through time as well as space when I caught sight of the woman standing in the kitchen, dancing and cooking eggs even as she greeted Amy.

She wore her light hair in a simple braid which fell halfway down the back of her denim vest atop a garishly bright shirt, a combination that went surprisingly well with the choice of brightly colored tights and leg warmers for her bottom half. At first, I hadn't really grasped what Charlotte meant when she said mages sometimes got stuck in moments of culture, but as I stared at this woman who looked for all intents and purposes like she'd stepped out of a portal in time, it clicked nicely.

“Grand Mage Cyndi Gussoff?”

The woman winced at my voice, twirling around in time with the beat and waving a spatula at me. “No need for titles, Mr. Fletcher. We're at my home; you can just call me Cyndi. Also, how do you like your eggs?”

“Over-easy,” I replied, trying for all I was worth to look unbothered by the curious greeting. Krystal and Charlotte had both said to roll with it, so I was doing my damndest to roll like the best of them. “And if we're eschewing titles, please call me Fred.”

A curious, cheerful gaze greeted my request. “Interesting. You know, you're the first vampire I've ever dealt with who didn't fight me on ignoring titles. Not to mention took me up on the eggs. Usually you folks are stuffier, and strict about sticking to blood.”

“I'm still a relatively new vampire, all things considered. I was only turned a few years ago. Perhaps the stuffiness comes with age.” I walked over

and took a seat next to Amy, who had grabbed a bar stool at the kitchen's counter and hunkered down. "As for food . . . well, I spent most of my life human. Blood is delectable, but there many other flavors to enjoy."

"Why am I not surprised that Amy managed to find the only fun vampire out there?" Cyndi cracked two more eggs into a fresh pan—one I wasn't sure had been on the stove moments prior—and let them cook.

"To be fair, I'm the least fun member of my clan. If I'd brought along Lillian, you'd have seen a vampire with far more appetite for life than I have."

Cyndi poked the eggs gently with her spatula. "Appetite is never the issue I run into with vampires; you've all got plenty of that. But most of the time, it's for the life that's flowing through our veins. That's why I was a bit concerned when one of our top earners suddenly lined herself up with a gentleman of your . . . persuasion. Amy is an up-and-comer in the magical world, you know. We've all got a lot of hope for what she'll accomplish one day. So you'll forgive me for wanting to meet this vampire of hers in person, just to make sure everything is on the up-and-up. You wouldn't be the first to blackmail or trap a mage and turn them into a living meal."

It was a fair concern, and one I'd been braced for. The vampire stereotypes were dangerous and well-earned. Even having only met a few, I could understand her worry. "Let me assure you, Gran—er, Cyndi, that I would never hurt Amy, or any of my clan members in such a manner. We are friends, first and foremost, and treat one another with the respect entailed in such a relationship."

"That's what everyone I talked to about you said, which is why I decided to have this meeting and see for myself," Cyndi replied. "But let's save the nitty-gritty for after breakfast. My family had a rule that I've kept with me through the years: no politics, religion, or business during meal times. We're going to talk, at length, Fred. Just not until after breakfast."

I contemplated pushing the matter, but Amy shook her head as my mouth opened. Evidently, this wasn't a trick or a test, which meant my only polite recourse was to respect the rules of her dinner table while I was a guest in her home. It was nerve-racking, yet also a bit reassuring. After the nightmare of dealing with Petre and the Turva clan, a simple request for peace over a meal felt strangely grounded.

Teleportation and eggs. If the level of weirdness stayed this high, I might just be able to hold my own until the end.

3.

The eggs were quite good, which was surprising. Not because I'd assumed a high-ranking mage would be unable to cook, but because I never actually saw Cyndi do anything more than dump the eggs into a pan and heat them up while we made small talk. I'll admit, I'm not a veteran chef; however, even I know the importance of things like salt and pepper in basic dishes. Yet, when they arrived on a plate in front of me, the eggs were seasoned with shredded cheese and diced chives atop them. As far as magic went, I doubt it ranked higher than a parlor trick, but I was still a bit impressed as I went to work on breakfast.

Amy, on the other hand, may not have even tasted her food. She blazed through it, stuffing the eggs down as quickly as Cyndi could fill her plate. Granted, Amy had always been one with a prodigious appetite, but there was something different about this. It was like she was stress-eating, trying to hide her nerves in her plate. That was both interesting and worrisome; Amy was never the type to get anxious. Even when we'd been stuck in a room with therian lackeys pounding on the door, trying to find a way to free Gideon from a magical prison, Amy had kept her cool. But this cheerful woman with dated fashion had put her on edge, and I trusted Amy's judgment enough to take note of that. Nice as Cyndi was acting, that didn't change the fact that this was a formal visit, not a social one.

At last the final helping of eggs was consumed, Cyndi managing to put away nearly as many helpings as Amy. Part of me wondered if something about using magic sped up one's metabolism, but there wasn't time to ask before Cyndi dropped her plate into the sink. I winced, waiting for the smash or clatter, yet there was only silence.

"Don't worry, Fred," Cyndi assured me, clearly taking note of my reaction. "The plates can't be broken. They were only partially real to begin with. Once their purpose was served, they fell all the way back to not existing."

I glanced at Amy, wondering if there was clarification on the way, but in response, she simply hurled her own plate over her shoulder. Quick as I spun to watch it fall, the plate vanished in the fraction of a moment it left my sight, or perhaps it ceased to exist altogether. Taking a moment, I steadied myself, keeping in mind that there would be many things I didn't understand when dealing with mages. What mattered wasn't knowing how these things worked, I had merely to accept that they did and work within that reality. It was the only way I'd make it through this without getting hopelessly sidetracked.

"Thank you for the lovely meal." I scooped up my own plate and set it carefully into the sink, purposefully not looking to see whether it was still

there or not once I let go. “It’s been some time since I did breakfast late at night, which is what time my internal clock believes it to be. Speaking of, Cyndi, do you mind if I ask where we are? Given the change from night to day, I can only imagine we crossed quite a distance.”

“It’s a fair question, but not one you’ll be getting an answer to.” Somehow, Cyndi managed to still sound cheerful even as she turned me down. “The politics of magic are not always above board, so I make it a point not to let the location of my homes or myself at any given time become widely known. As for the sunshine, don’t overthink it too much.” Looking around as though there might be people listening, she waved me in close, and then whispered loudly in my ear. “*It’s imported.*”

It was right about here that I began to consider the possibility that Cyndi was less eccentric than she seemed and might be outright messing with me for her amusement. Whether that was the case or not, I was still a guest in her home, so I held my tongue and looked perplexed, which wasn’t a very hard look to pull off given how I felt. “What mages can do truly seems to be astounding. Now that breakfast is done, however, may I ask if it’s proper to begin our official discussions?”

“Asking permission to start . . . you might be the most polite vampire I’ve ever met, Fred.” Grabbing a towel, Cyndi cleaned off her hands and motioned to the living room, where a pair of large, overstuffed golden couches were waiting. I’ll give Cyndi this: the woman picked a signature color and stuck with it. We made our way over, Amy and I taking one couch, and Cyndi sitting on the other.

There was a lot of silence as we sat there, until Cyndi snapped her fingers once. I blinked in surprise, and when my eyes opened, there were three champagne flutes filled with bubbling orange liquid on the coffee table between us. “Can’t very well do brunch business without mimosas,” Cyndi said, reaching out and taking one. I mirrored her, though I made no motion to actually drink from the glass. Alcohol might not mean much to an undead constitution; however, I’d been around Amy long enough to know there were plenty of other chemicals that could rob me of my wits. She seemed to be thinking similarly, as Amy sprinkled a bit of purple powder over her own drink before gulping it down.

“Let’s get down to business, as you’ve requested.” If Cyndi was bothered by me not drinking, she hid it well, taking a long drink from her own glass without so much as a waver in her smile. “Fred, you may not realize this, but Amy is a very special alchemist. Her natural talent is incredible, her magical capacity means that one day she could be an archmage, and she’s received personal lessons from the King of the West. I know we mages are mere humans with cheap tricks to you real supernatural creatures, but you’ll find—”

“I beg your pardon?” The words slipped out, and if I could have blushed, I would have. Interrupting someone during such a formal occasion was the height of rudeness, and I knew far better than to let such a failing of the tongue occur. “I’m so sorry, that came out in surprise. I didn’t mean to interrupt. Please, continue.”

“No, let’s halt here for a moment. What did I say that took you off guard?” She leaned in, just a little, and I caught a hungry glint in her eye, not unlike how she’d stared down at the eggs.

“It’s just . . . your comment about me thinking less of mages. I was surprised to hear such an expectation. The things you all can do . . . I feel like I’ve barely scratched the surface, and it’s mind-blowing. Do the other parahumans really look down on you?”

Cyndi took a long draw of her mimosa and turned her eyes to Amy. “He sounds curiously sincere.”

The champagne flute in Amy’s hand was turned up, bottom in the air as she finished draining it. I also noted that her glowing hair had shifted color to a lavender shade, one that seemed to be actively moving around as I looked at it. “Fred is a bit of an odd one. Abandoned vampire, so the old prejudices weren’t bred into him.”

“I see. That would account for much.” Cyndi turned back to me, still grinning. “To answer your question, Fred, mages are rarely granted the same respect as other parahumans, until they need something from us. Because our skills can be learned, theoretically every human could be a mage, which they believe cheapens what we do. Never mind the fact that anyone can also paint, yet only a few will be true masters of the craft, while many will merely push colors around a canvas. The mere fact that our skills are teachable is a strike against us. Again, until they need something.”

“For what it’s worth, I know Amy is special, even among people who wield magic, and I value her highly. As a friend, and as an alchemist.” In truth, the former was the only real part I’d ever looked for in Amy. While her skill with potions and the like had helped our friends many a time, I’d never needed much from her in the way of magic.

That seemed to please Cyndi. She settled deeper into her couch, pushing herself back against the cushions. “Well, this meeting is going better than I’d dared to hope. Very well, Fred. You seem like a genuine fellow. Plus, you didn’t trip any of the wards I set up to detect dishonesty, and Amy isn’t flashing any of the secret signals to indicate that she needs help, so it appears to me that there’s nothing unsavory afoot here. A mage belonging to a vampire’s clan is unorthodox and strange, but as a whole, we mages tend to be less hung up on tradition than some of the older parahumans. If she’s happy being with you, and you’re happy having her, then I don’t see why you’d need me to intervene.”

I started to relax, right up until I felt something land on my lap. Glancing down, I found myself staring at a stack of white papers, all neatly typed-out. “What’s this?”

“Just crossing the *Ts* and dotting the *Is*,” Cyndi said. She swirled her glass in her hand, and it refilled with mimosa before my eyes. “Since Amy is part of your clan, you could technically use that position to try and force her out of various contracts, or into renegotiations for deals long settled. That contract is you waiving the right to cause such mischief. You don’t seem the type to start trouble, but the higher-ups will only be at peace once you show them that by signing.”

I picked up the contract, eyeing Amy carefully as I did. She still looked nervous, but not outright bothered. If she was worried about something, this contract probably wasn’t it. Still, I’d spent far too long in the business sector to sign anything without reading it carefully. Taking a cursory flip through the pages, I noticed that I wouldn’t be signing away any more rights than what Cyndi had indicated, but there were a lot of those rights I’d be giving up. Just how much power did a leader have over his clan?

“If you don’t mind, I’d like to read this thoroughly,” I said.

“Of course,” Cyndi replied. “I’d expect nothing less. I’ve got an office you can use; please look over it until you are absolutely satisfied.”

“Great.” I took the pages and stood, putting my mimosa back on the coffee table, untouched. “While I’m at it, would you mind if I looked at copies of all the contracts Amy is currently beholden to? Wouldn’t be very smart of me to sign away these rights without knowing if she might need some renegotiation help.”

“Certainly. They’ll be in the office when you arrive.” Despite the agreeable words, I noticed that Cyndi’s smile dipped, just for a moment, at my request. It was too late to retract it though, and even if I could, it wouldn’t have been a wise move. There was something in those contracts that the mages didn’t want me to see, which meant I needed to hunt it down. Knowledge was always useful after all, especially when they might have a grip on one of my good friends.

4.

Mage contracts, as I learned that day, were extremely arcane. I realize that sounds like I'm trying to be cute and make something of a pun, so let me pause to assure you that I mean the word exactly as it was intended: these contracts used outdated terms and language that was highly difficult for anyone not exceptionally well-versed in business matters. While my own contract was simple and straightforward, the ones that Amy had signed were a whole other level of complexity. I spent several hours looking through them, using my laptop to cross-check digital books on parahuman law, and by the end, I had reached an undeniable conclusion: Amy was getting screwed.

Her business, which had originally been funded by more established mages who covered the start-up costs, was paying back huge percentages every month for interest rates that ballooned and escalated seemingly almost at random. Whoever had built these trappings was a fiscal wizard; they'd set Amy up so that no matter how her business grew, it was virtually impossible for her to get out of the initially incurred debt, in spite of the fact that she'd now paid off the amount by nearly ten times over. It was no wonder they didn't want anyone having the power to force a renegotiation for any of Amy's contracts. Cyndi could have probably paid for this beach house and all the "imported" sunshine off Amy's previous year's payments alone. Did she have any idea how badly she was getting screwed, or was she, like so many parahumans before her, just cutting a check every month without really questioning where it all went? It was the biggest failing I'd found in the supernatural world: no one bothered to understand the ins and outs of their financial burdens the way they should have. Someone really needed to start an education outreach program, or something along those lines.

For now, however, I had my plate full with Amy's situation. My first impulse was to kick down the door, stride into the living room, and boldly declare that we would be voiding everything she signed and the mages could go to hell if they didn't like it. I quickly tossed that idea aside for several reasons, firstly being that I didn't know if I actually had the authority to do that, and secondly because I'd never really been the type for striding or bold declarations. While the second issue wasn't going away anytime soon, I did have the power to change the first problem. Cyndi had, mercifully, left the wi-fi password along with my stack of contracts in the office—a room that was mostly tasteful, aside from the framed album covers of eighties bands—so I composed an email to the only lawyer who dealt with parahumans that I knew and trusted: Asha Patel. Finances I could handle, but for this, I was going to require a precise understanding of the laws applying to me, Amy, and Cyndi, so it was time to consult an expert. Hopefully by now, it was approaching morning in Colorado, so she'd see the email and get back to me. I'd have

texted as well, just to cover my bases, but there was zero reception inside Cyndi's beach house. Given her concerns over privacy, it was hard to begrudge her that, though it did make my task more difficult.

That done, I shut my laptop and headed back to the living room, where I found Amy still seated on the couch. She'd pulled a book from her bag, some weighty tome with a language I didn't speak, and was deep in its thrall when I entered. At least, I thought she was until she spoke, eyes never leaving the page. "You finish signing yet? I'd rather not stay here any longer than we have to."

I looked around, scanning for Cyndi's bubbly presence, but her braid and denim were nowhere to be seen. "Where's our host?"

"Went to check on some experiments and take a dip on the beach," Amy replied. "She tried to make small talk after you left, but eventually she got the hint that I wasn't interested."

"Why not?" I sat down on the couch opposite Amy, where Cyndi had been before. "Granted, the fashion is a bit odd, but she seems nice enough."

"Cyndi's fine for what she is; I just don't enjoy associating with anyone like her." Amy let out a long sigh, closing the book and dropping it into her bag. "It's hard to explain what magic is to someone who has never held it or molded it, but trust me when I say that it's incredible. The feeling . . . try to imagine holding the power of creation between your palms, shaping reality with your will, altering the very composition of existence, even on a small scale. Every mage who has reached journeyman-level has felt that experience, but instead of chasing after it, some of them do what Cyndi did. They have the world's greatest miracle in their grasp, and rather than devoting themselves to studying and understanding it, they get caught up in the politics of deciding who should wield what. She could be an archmage by now, if she hadn't decided to become a politician."

I'd heard magic referred to as an art before—even Cyndi had compared them to painters just a few hours ago—but it wasn't until that moment that I truly understood that Amy saw herself as an artist as well as a scientist. It certainly explained some of her more reckless, impulsive behaviors through the years. She was swept up in her craft, taking bold risks and experimenting on herself to achieve that fleeting sense of perfection. But it also meant that I needed to rethink my plan for her contracts. Bad deals though they were, I wasn't the one bound to them. Being a leader didn't mean deciding what was right for the people trusting me, it meant finding out what they wanted, and then fighting for that.

"If you'd like me to, I'll sign the contracts right now and we can leave," I offered. "However, I feel you should know that the deals you're already in are terrible. They're gutting your finances deeply, and if we can push the terms even a little bit, we could drastically change how much income



you're keeping. That's only if you want to, though. If you're happy with things as they are, then that's all I need to hear. And if you're not, then I'll use every ounce of leverage my position offers to get you into better deals."

"Fucking money. It always comes back to that, doesn't it? You know, when I first found magic, when I first discovered how much more there was to the world than what I'd been led to believe, I thought this kind of shit was behind me. Who would spend a lifetime chasing the almighty dollar when there was fucking *magic* in the world, right?" Amy reached into her bag and pulled out a bottle that had once been full of water, but was currently holding something that looked like blue lava. She sipped it slowly, the veins under her skin glowing visibly once she did. "Turns out, even the power to reshape the world around us has a dollar value tacked on. What am I going to do if I get more of it? I like my house, and my lab. I make enough to do my research, and I never miss rent. I just can't see how it's worth the fight."

"For you, it's probably not," I said. And that was true. While they were gouging Amy left and right, she was a highly valued alchemist with a robust list of clients, including the King of the West. She made enough to be fine. "But it is worth noting that nothing about that contract seemed tailored to you, Amy. Most of it looked like boilerplate. I think they've used those terms to get a lot of new mages under their thumbs, people who didn't know any better or couldn't imagine they'd need to get a contract vetted after just discovering magic. If you had more of your own income, you could afford to invest in new mages yourself, offering them much more fair conditions than what they'd otherwise see."

Amy took a long gulp from her lava drink, her veins shining so brightly that, for a moment, I could actually see the blood pumping through them. I had no idea what that, or any of her other potions, did. She was constantly fiddling with her own chemistry, brain and body, which probably should have made me concerned. But at the end of the day, there were few people I knew who showed as much wisdom and keen judgment when it mattered as Amy had in the past. Sure, she'd also gotten messed up on her own product before, and had caused us to hunt through a park for her; however, that was during a peaceful moment. In the clutch, Amy was someone I could count on. So I waited, patient and silent, as she considered all the things she might be able to do with more of her income left in her own hands.

"I really don't want to deal with any of that." It was a disappointing answer; however, I resolved myself to respect Amy's wishes. As it turned out though, she wasn't done speaking yet. "It sounds like a huge pain in the ass. All I want to do is work on my magic, hang out with my friends, and maybe hit a nice buffet here and there. Even if you were able to do something with my contracts, it would be this big ordeal and probably get a lot of other mages

chapped at me. Then I'd actually have to deal with doing the investing and what-not, which is even more trouble and a drain on my time. No, I'm not doing that stuff. But at the same time, you're right. If I turn a blind eye to the shit the older mages are pulling, I become complicit in it, and I'm not cool with that either. Since both options suck, I'm going to just hand all of that shit over to my business manager. And since you're the only one here, I guess that's you, Fred."

"Flattered as I am by the offer, are you sure you wouldn't prefer to find someone more qualified?" I asked. "I know next to nothing about mages or how they work."

"But you've got lots of time to figure it out. It's not like I'm going to have enough spare cash to start funding new mages right out of the gate." Amy caught sight of the expression on my face and let out a low whistle. "Wait, I will? Just how much are these jerks taking every month?"

"Let's just say that if I cut your payments in half and take ten percent of the savings as my fee, you'll still be one of my most lucrative clients."

"Damn. Okay, so we'll take some time to figure things out while we let the cash grow, assuming you even can bust me out of those contracts at all." Amy finished off her bottle and got up from the couch. "I trust you, Fred. Do your best to handle this, and when the dust settles, we'll go from there. You've got my permission to renegotiate on my behalf, if you've got the grounds to do so. Just try not to take too long. This place kind of gives me the willies."

Looking around, I took in all the sunshine coming in from every angle. The more I stayed here, the less it seemed like a warm welcome, and the more it felt like an implicit threat. If the glass broke, I'd have almost nowhere to hide. It was a subtle form of intimidation, and one I might have been imagining; however, I didn't put it past Cyndi. It seemed mages counted on being underestimated by other parahumans, and that wasn't a mistake I planned to make.

"Hopefully it won't be long," I assured Amy. "As soon as I hear back from Asha, we can get this started."

5.

Neither stalling nor feigning ignorance had ever been skills I possessed much talent with, which made me deeply thankful that Cyndi didn't try to hurry me along throughout the day. She only popped in twice—once to let me know lunch was being cooked, and once to bring along a nice pressed sandwich with a side of homemade slaw. I couldn't fault her as a host; if nothing else, she was considerate of her guests while still offering personal space. And that was a good thing, because it took several hours for Asha to get back to me.

Not that I was sitting on my duff the whole time, by any means. While Asha calculated my angles of approach, I was working on a new set of contracts for Amy. I built a few variations, depending on how much leverage I would actually be walking into the negotiation with, but all of them were built around the idea of reorganizing Amy's "debt" (I hesitate to use the word, truthfully, since the principal sum had been so thoroughly paid off) and getting her paid out entirely from the burden in the next few years. Timelines and numbers were tweaked so that I'd have wiggle room; however, even the most placating of options was still fairly aggressive. They'd been screwing over my friend, and I knew it, and I wanted them to *know* that I'd caught them.

By the time Asha's return email arrived, I was more or less ready to present, and the news she sent was quite encouraging. In parahuman terms, my role as the head of a clan was something like a parent or guardian in the mundane world. I had to give permission for any of my people to enter serious fiscal or legal arrangements, and deals lacking such permission were retroactively suspect until finalized. It was, in truth, a lot more power and responsibility than I was comfortable having over anyone. For once though, I managed to keep things in perspective. What I was entitled to do and what I did were wholly different values; the power was only bad if it was abused. At that moment, the work I was doing came with Amy's blessing, so I was still seeing her wishes through like I would for any client. It was like holding a power-of-attorney, nothing more, and I promised myself to never let it grow beyond that.

Armed with legal backing and a slew of potential contracts, I finally emerged from the office, just in time for what was ostensibly dinner, although it was hard to mark any change of time in this beach house. The sun never moved. The house was always flooded with a gentle, yet full light, like one would encounter in early morning. Part of me wondered if Cyndi only dismissed it when she slept. Another piece of me questioned if she slept at all.

"Fred, so lovely to see you," Cyndi called. This time, she had apparently skipped the cooking, as there were a stack of pizza boxes lined up on the counter. "Don't worry, I told them firmly no garlic anywhere on the

pizza.”

“I greatly appreciate the consideration, and I’m pleased to report that I’ve finished looking over the contracts.”

“Good for you. Those things are dreadful, aren’t they? So thick and technical, I can’t believe you managed to read them all. And in just one day, too. Very impressive.” She tore into a piece of pepperoni, leaving me unsure of whether she was joking with me or not. Cyndi had obviously done some homework; she must know I ran an accounting firm. Did she really think I wouldn’t be able to parse through their contracts? I glanced to Amy for clarification, but she merely shrugged her shoulders and grabbed a slice of mushroom-and-onion pizza from a different box.

“Now that you’re done with the reading, I assume you’ve signed your contract and we can finally relax and get to know one another. I’ve got a few board games in the closet we can play, or I could transport us all to somewhere nice at nighttime. I haven’t been to Paris in a few weeks; that might make for a good trip.”

“Cyndi, forgive me if I misspoke and led you to a false conclusion.” No sense in putting this off; she was going to realize sooner or later that railroading us toward fun wouldn’t deter me from my job. “I have not signed anything, nor do I intend to do so.”

Her slice of pizza froze halfway to her lips, lowering slightly as she turned to look at me better. “Oh? And why is that?”

“Because I fully intend to exercise my rights as the leader of the House of Fred in relation to the mage Amy Wells. Primarily, my capacity to overturn existing contracts in favor of renegotiation. If you’d like to set up a time for a formal discussion of the issue, I’d be more than willing to accommodate that. You’ve been a gracious host, and isn’t my intent to try and catch you off guard and unprepared, so we can adjourn if needed.” I was dearly hoping Cyndi would take me up on the offer, because I was still a little too aware of just how much home field-advantage she held in our current situation. The law was on my side, yes, but we were in a sunlight-filled house where she seemed to freely manipulate matter.

“I see. You disappoint me, Fred. For a moment, I really thought you were going to be different, but it seems you’re just another ‘true’ parahuman looking to use mages. The only difference is that you’ll be squeezing one for coins rather than magic or blood.”

Cyndi rose from her seat at the bar, placid look and grin both quickly dissolving. What remained in their place was a set of fierce, determined eyes, the sort that belonged to someone smart and dedicated enough to have achieved such mastery over the domain of magic. The tension in the air nearly crackled, and it might actually have sparked a few times—with magic, nothing is off the table. Before Cyndi could unleash either a verbal or

mystical tirade upon me, however, Amy stepped in between us.

“Fred is doing what I asked him to do. Nothing more. If you’ve got a problem, take it up with the jackass elders who use money to keep us under their thumbs. And make no mistake here, Cyndi, Fred is acting with my full cooperation and what sure sounds like the backing of our treaties. Try to do anything to him other than talk calmly about contracts or terms, and I will protect him like I’d protect any friend getting attacked.”

Previously, I’d thought the room’s tension had reached a zenith, but I quickly realized how wrong I was. Cyndi and Amy stared one another down, and it was quickly apparent that while I was a catalyst today, whatever was between them had been simmering for a long time. Cyndi’s smile was back, although it looked nothing like the dopey grin she’d masqueraded behind all day. There was danger in those gleaming teeth, and a wicked curve at the top of her lips. “So, is today the day you finally do it then, Mage Wells? Are you going to challenge me for my title at long last? You may be a prodigy and the favorite now, but don’t think for a moment that you’re the first to try and take my position. I won’t be as easy a stepping stone as you’ve imagined.”

“That’s the problem with you old casters; you forgot how to think outside the box.” Amy reached into her pocket and pulled out a small vial of green liquid. “The moment I break this, an entire square mile is going to be flooded with a gas that, while non-lethal, is going to leave you itchy, doped up, and all around miserable for the next few days. Since Fred doesn’t breathe and I dosed myself with the antidote this afternoon, I’d say that means you’ll be the only one affected.”

“Unless I transport it away,” Cyndi countered.

Amy snorted, almost a laugh but not quite. “You think I didn’t trap this bad boy in case of meddling? One bit of magic touches it, and the vial blows. It’s thin, too. Easy to break if someone tried to wrestle it out of my hands.”

“So, you’ll render me helpless, and then strike while I’m weakened?”

“No. We’d render you helpless, leave, and report whatever bullshit you tried to do through the proper channels,” Amy shot back. “I don’t want your fucking job. I don’t want to climb the political ladder at all. I just want to be left alone to do my work and live my life. Now, if you want to deal with Fred like what he is—a friend, and the head of my clan exercising his legal rights—then we can go on. If you’re planning to try anything else, then take a deep breath and hold it for as long as you can.”

Everything fell silent, and I found myself wondering if Amy had an actual escape plan beyond her vial. We were, after all, in a house we didn’t know the location of, surrounded by sunshine, so getting away was easier said than done. Thankfully, Cyndi’s body grew less tense, and she raised her right hand.

“Upon my magic, I swear that, so long as he acts in accordance with the laws of parahumans, I shall do the same. I will make no acts of aggression, only defense, and even then, only if a threat is clear, present, and provable. Does that satisfy you, Amy?”

“It’ll do.” Amy relaxed, putting away the vial once more.

“Good. But with that settled, I think your intervention has proven that three heads are not better than two, so with your permission, I would like to speak with Fred in private,” Cyndi said.

Amy’s head began to cautiously nod. “I guess that’s okay, if you—”

It wasn’t that Amy stopped talking; her mouth was still open, tongue still midway through forming a word. But she, like everything else in the house, had frozen still. Having already seen a time bubble before, I was less struck with shock by the sudden temporal shift, though I was worried by how easily Cyndi seemed to have conjured such a potent spell.

“I needed her permission, otherwise she’d have fought me tooth and nail,” Cyndi said. I think she meant it as an explanation, though it didn’t help me understand much. “Well, Fredrick Fletcher of the humorously named House of Fred, it seems you and I need to have a negotiation. Let us adjourn to the place where properly skilled mages settle such matters, shall we?”

Before I had a chance to answer—not that I imagined it would have made much difference—the entire world fell away from us.

6.

Despite my friendship with Amy, I'd never been much for drugs. Even in my human days, when leaving my state of perception behind didn't require the talents of a specialized alchemist, I'd eschewed such mental adventures. Control was a thing I felt I had a fleeting amount of in my life, and I never felt compelled to give up the small amount of it I possessed. I say all that to lend context to the next statement: while having never actually experienced an acid trip, I imagine that they are quite similar to what happened when Cyndi pulled us out of the beach house.

Every wall fell away, dropping off into space and nothingness, from what I could tell. There was no sunshine waiting for us, however. Instead, it was a sky of stars, too many to be accurate, with glowing colors one never normally encountered in the real world. We floated up toward them, sometimes racing at incredible speeds, sometimes barely drifting, until we finally came to a stop. Before us was a conference room table, a football stadium, a battlefield littered with bodies and armor, and chessboard. I don't mean each of those things was there side-by-side. It was all of them at once, and none of them. Cyndi and I were right next to one another, and also miles apart. I understand how mad this all sounds—trust me, I do—so please take solace in my poor description by remembering that, as frustrating as it is to read about such striking contrasts, living them was a far greater challenge. Especially for someone as rooted in reality as me.

"Do you like it?" Cyndi's voice was all around me, not an echo or a shout, yet it filled the space we occupied effortlessly. "It's an old spell the archmages' created ages ago. One that only the grand mages and higher can tap into. Amy likes to pretend there's nothing to be gained from playing the political game, but membership *does* have its privileges."

"If I ask something like, 'where are we'? I assume I won't get a straight answer, right?" Cyndi could hear me, I saw her register my words, but I decided not to wait on a pointless answer. "Instead, let me ask you what the purpose of this place is. I had everything I needed to discuss terms back in the beach house."

"I'm sure you did, and you'll have it all here, too. For the record, you and I are still in the beach house. This is just a space our minds are occupying. See, the trouble with making deals around other parahumans is that they like to throw their might and powers around. You ever tried to negotiate with a fey? Forget it; they'll glamour you into signing over your whole savings for a twig. Mages built this place to remove those advantages. Here, we are mere projections of our thoughts. You can't hurt me, nor I you, nor can you utilize any powers you might have gained from drinking other parahumans' blood."

While I'm sure Cyndi meant the statement to scare me, to rip away advantages I'd been counting on, in truth, I was more fascinated than anything else. The mere idea of being able to deal with other parahumans on grounds like this was enough to make me want to crack open a magic book, if not for the fact that corpses, even ones as lively as I, couldn't cast. Still, if the mages rolled this out widely, it could be incredible. Conference calls would never be able to match this level of interaction.

"Wow. This is incredible." I spun around once, doing a front somersault through the air like a child in a pool. Not the most dignified opening, I'll admit; however, it was hard not to be a little charmed by the experience as a whole.

Cyndi was grinning again as she nodded her agreement. "Incredible, and useful. Because this does more than just yank us out of our bodies, Fred. It puts up a few negotiation safeguards. Whatever we swear to in here, it's binding. Binding on a *deep* level. You can't break a contract signed here; you can't even contemplate the idea of it. And you can't lie, at least not without it being plainly obvious."

I finished my somersault and took a standing position once more. "Fantastic. That will speed things along. So, how do I summon what I need? Do I just think of it—whoops, looks like I answered my own question there, huh?" Midway through my sentence, a stack of pages had appeared in my hand. Looking them over, I found it was the contract I'd planned on opening my negotiations with, replicated precisely. Somehow, the spell had pulled a perfect copy from my memories, fleeting as they were. Archmages didn't do things by half-measures, it seemed. "Here, let me think you a set as well, and we can get started."

Another stack of pages appeared directly in front of Cyndi, who reached out and grabbed them, but made no attempt to read so much as even the first sentence. She was eyeing me uncertainly; somehow, I could actually *see* the confusion surrounding her. There really were no secrets in this place. "You made contracts?"

"Of course. What did you expect me to do, just tell you Amy worked for me now and barge out the door?" I was joking, yet from the combination of her face and the sense of surprise that rippled around her, I realized that that was more or less *exactly* what she'd been expecting. "Cyndi, I won't insult your intelligence by assuming you didn't do your homework before inviting me for this visit, so why are you so surprised to see me doing business like any accountant would?"

"Oh, I read up on you, Fred. Or more accurately, I read up on your cover. I'd say you went over-the-top with it, but I've committed pretty hard to mine, so that might be overstepping. Seriously though, the accounting firm wasn't enough for you? Sweater vests, slacks, and glasses, too? You don't



think you're playing this role a bit too hard?" There was no uncertainty around Cyndi now. She was sure of her words, which only made them all the more confusing to me.

"You expected me to be less competent because of my fashion sense?"

"Come on, Fred, we're playing the same game." Cyndi lifted her arms and twirled, sending out a shower of glowing lights that illuminated her dated outfit. "Nobody knows this act better than me. I bet it's just as easy to underestimate a vampire in a sweater vest as it is a mage in leg warmers. But I'm not falling for my own scam. You're playing a part, a wolf in sheep's clothing, and now is the time to let the facade drop so we can get down to business."

And with that, it all fell into place. She thought all of it—my firm, my job, my reputation, each piece was part of a con to make people think I was a harmless, numbers-loving vampire. "Cyndi, you just said it was impossible to get away with lying here, right? Please look at me very carefully."

She halted her spin, training her eyes on me.

"None of this is an act. I wear these clothes because I like them and they feel right on me. I do my job because I love it, and I believe I'm making the parahuman world a slightly better place. I came to represent Amy because she is my friend, one who has saved my life before. You keep waiting for me to surprise you and drop the mask, but there is no mask to drop. This is me, plain and simple."

Her eyes went wide, and a whole new wave of uncertainty rolled off of her. I could see it all, the surprise, the doubt, and then the realization that here there could be no falsehoods. Finally, I saw a glow of acceptance surround her, and it was unexpectedly beautiful.

"My apologies, Fred. It seems I misjudged you. For all the times I've railed against other parahumans thinking little of mages, I was quick to lump you in with all the other vampires. I am sincerely sorry."

"Quite all right. It happens more than you might think," I said. "All that matters is that we put it behind us and get down to determining how to proceed with Amy's contracts."

Cyndi raised her hands, and a page appeared in front of me. "Since I still feel guilty about the error, I'm make this simple and clean. The elders authorized me to give you up to fifty percent of her income each month in exchange for not overturning the contracts. If you want more than that, you'll have to walk away and wait for them to reach out, but they'll be petty about it."

Carefully, I checked over the page she had presented. Unlike Amy's contract, this was quite simple. Nothing would change, except that half of the

fund Amy paid toward her “debt” would go to me. While that would make things easy—all I’d need to do was hand Amy her cash right back—it still didn’t address the long-term fiscal robbery she’d be enduring by allowing things to stand as they were. It was an appeasement, not a negotiation, and for the first time since arriving, I had a doubt about Cyndi.

“Forgive me if this is insulting, I don’t mean it to be, but are you actually trained in parahuman accounting regulations and law?”

“You think I have time to learn all that and get this good at magic?” Cyndi asked. “Nah, like most grand mages, I’m just here to keep the newer casters in line and deal with any issues that pop up. We tend to self-regulate more than other parahuman groups, for obvious reasons. I can contact someone with that knowledge, if needed though.”

“Then you should do that.” Tempting as it was to crumple the page, we were just getting onto good terms, and I saw no need to undo that progress. Instead, I folded her offer gently in half and set it aside. “Because I didn’t come here to take a cut of Amy’s money. I came to create a stable, fair plan to pay off the remainder of her debt at reasonable interest rates and to move her entirely out of the pseudo-debt you’ve caged her in. And I came *prepared*.”

More pages showed up around me, documents detailing my rights as the head of her clan as well as the basic principles of financing. Books appeared as well, though I’ll admit that, at that point, I may have been showing off a little. Within seconds, I was surrounded by stacks of pages and a library’s worth of law and finance books. There may have even been a few rogue numbers just floating about, added more for effect than function. That said, they seemed to be working.

“Well, shit,” Cyndi said as the last of my tools was gathered around me. “In retrospect, maybe I should have left us in the beach house. But don’t count me out just yet, Fred. I may not know the details, but I know what my people are entitled to.”

It was my turn to grin as I sent over a new contract—one of the more aggressive versions. “Then, by all means, let’s get down to it.”

7.

Have faith, dear readers, for I am not so ignorant of my profession's reputation that I would bore you with the details of our negotiation. While I would certainly enjoy rehashing each aspect of the exchange, and I'm sure those of you in the accounting field would relish reading such a play-by-play, I understand that to the vast majority of people reading this, it would be incomprehensible. Thus, I shall spare you the tedious details and simply skip to the end result.

Cyndi, in spite of her initial reticence, managed to regain her footing and put on quite an impressive display of contract-negotiating skill. It clearly wasn't her field of specialty, yet she held her own regardless. Still, this very much *was* a field in which I was competent, and by the time we'd reached an agreement, Amy's finances were in far better shape. As things stood, she'd be free from any debt within three years, assuming her business stayed level, and the release would be even sooner than that if her income grew, which, based on history, it probably would.

By the time Amy snapped out of frozen time, I'd finished printing off pages, and Cyndi and I had signed nearly every necessary line to make it all official, since oaths sworn in the dream realm didn't translate neatly to paper without someone typing them out.

"How did it go?" Amy stretched her jaw like it was sore, which made sense since it had been hanging open since time froze, but very much didn't make sense because *time had frozen*. Or had it? I realized that the only proof of that I had was silence and Amy growing still. It was probably a lot easier to kill an air conditioner and bind another mage than it was to entirely halt the flow of time. My eyes darted over to Cyndi as she responded. I'd gotten the better of her on this exchange only because she'd underestimated me. Something told me that if we ever met again, I wasn't going to have that advantage, and she was far wilier than the outfit implied.

"You've made a competent friend," Cyndi said, making a grand swoop of a signature on the final line. "And I've met worse leaders in my time. Fred will walk you through the specifics, and I'm sure you'll be quite happy with what you see. Congratulations, Amy. To be frank, I didn't think you had it in you."

"The ability to ask my clan's leader to get me a better deal? It wasn't really that hard." Amy was eyeing Cyndi as well; she didn't trust something about that last statement. As it turned out, she was right to be suspicious.

Pushing the documents together, Cyndi clapped them against the table so they made a neat, orderly lined-up stack. "No, the willpower to push back against the system. Few mages ever do, you know. They're too preoccupied with their own studies and work. So long as they have enough to

live on, which we always make sure they do, that's enough to keep them content. The rare ones who try to fight off the yolk we've shackled them with, and the even more precious few who succeed, are the mages we know to keep an eye on. They've got the makings of what it takes to help run things one day."

Amy darted back so quickly that, for a moment, I thought Cyndi had struck her with some manner of invisible attack. She put her arms up and waved them furiously. "Nope. Nuh-uh. Not me, not happening. All I wanted was a fair amount of the money I was making so I could do a little good with it. Maybe give rookie casters a better option than I had. That's it. You all can keep your politics and your bullshit. I want none of it."

"Of course. The sort of woman who would fight for a larger percentage of her income and funnel it into less binding financial opportunities for new mages would never have any desire to get involved in the greater mage community. Come on, Amy. Your very explanation proves that sooner or later, you'll start playing the game. If you want to make changes, it's inevitable." Cyndi handed me part of her document stack, and I handed her part of mine.

Now, we all had copies of everything, and Amy's release was nice and official. Although, the more they talked, the more I started wondering if I'd accidentally walked her into a different, more complex cage—and if I'd really come out as far ahead in my battle with Cyndi as I thought. She sure didn't look like someone who'd gotten the short end of the stick; her grin was back, and wider than ever. What I didn't fully understand back then was that it's not the magic that makes mages dangerous. Well, okay, I mean yes, the magic absolutely makes mages dangerous, to say otherwise would be silly. But it's not the biggest threat when working with them. No, the most dangerous aspect of dealing with mages was that they all had minds sharp and smart enough to handle the working of magic, and it takes quite a brain to manage that.

"I still say it's not happening," Amy protested. "And if you two trading pages means this is over, can Fred and I go home now? I'm ready to be done with this place."

Cyndi checked a large golden watch on her wrist, then nodded. "It's well into nighttime back home for both of you, and the limo is still waiting, so I think you'll be fine to return now. You're both welcome to stay for a few more days, though. I'd be happy to walk you through what it takes to start climbing the political ladder, Amy."

"Raincheck." Amy paused, reconsidering her words. "On second thought, what's the right term for a 'never-check'? That, whatever that is, pretend I said it. Fred, grab your bag and let's go."

While I didn't want to be discourteous to our host, it was plain that

Amy was leaving soon, with or without me. Taking her cue, I went to the office to grab my laptop and travel bag, which was barely even opened. It was a shame, in a way. Some part of me had hoped for a little downtime, a bit of vacation amidst the work. Then again, if I was going to take a vacation, which I was overdue for, perhaps it would be better to do it officially. That way I could spend the time with Krystal. Maybe we'd head down for that weekend in Boarback, or go check out Alaska during the time with no sun. It was something to consider, at least, as I hauled my stuff back to the living room and down the entrance hall, where the golden door we'd come through had reappeared.

Amy and Cyndi were both there, waiting for me; although, just as I appeared, Cyndi gave Amy a large hug, pulling her in tight. "Don't be such a stranger. Come visit next time and hang out for a little while. I'll even hook a door to some dank lab where you can work when we're not out in the sun."

"If you promise not to talk politics, I'll promise to think about it," Amy replied, hugging her back. "And thanks for worrying, even if you didn't need to."

"You are on a strange journey, I won't deny that, but I think I've known that would be the case since the first lesson I gave you." Cyndi released Amy, turning to me. "As for you, Fred, it was a pleasure to meet you, and to negotiate with you. Next time the elders need some heavy lifting of our books, I know who I'll call."

"I'd welcome the opportunity." We forewent a hug in favor of a handshake, though Cyndi did pull me close just as we were about to part.

"Make sure you take good care of my student, Fred. I'm not so set in my ways that I can't make a quick trip to Colorado if I think it's warranted."

I glanced between the two women, momentarily confused. "Wait, I thought Gideon taught Amy?"

"He's given me lessons, sure, but do you really think he has the time or temperament to train a mage all the way up from scratch?" Amy asked. "Cyndi was my mentor. She watched over my education like I'm doing for Neil. Although, she was a lot more pushy about what I should do with my talents."

"I saw potential, and I tried to nurture it. I'm not apologizing for that." Cyndi released her grip on my hand and motioned to the door. "Now out, the both of you. I've got some jams to put on, and you're cramping my style."

Amy didn't need to hear any more than that; she grabbed the knob and yanked it open, revealing the dark interior of an old barn. We stepped through, the door slamming shut behind us, and just like that, the white walls covered in imported sunshine were gone. I let out a small sigh of relief. Enchanted glass or not, I hadn't felt entirely comfortable in a place with that

much light. It felt good to be back home, or at least back in the proper time zone. As soon as we walked out of the barn, the golden limo flashed its lights at us. I really didn't know if it had been waiting the whole time, or if Cyndi had somehow summoned it, and I didn't particularly care. It was there, that was the only thing that mattered, and once we were in it, it began driving us back to Charlotte Manor.

We didn't say much. Amy drank a few vials from her bag and downed a bottle of champagne on the ride, so that, by the time we made it to Charlotte Manor, her eyes were glowing yellow and sections of her hair were fighting with other strands. It was only when I reached for the door to let us out that Amy spoke.

"For what it's worth, I think you've been doing a good job. With heading the House of Fred, I mean. I know you've been worrying about it a lot, but you don't need to fret quite so much. Just keep making sure you're looking after your people's best interests, not what *you* might think they want, and you'll be fine. Take it from someone who had to figure out being an authority figure on the fly."

"Is Neil your first student?" I asked. Amy had always seemed so competent as a teacher, I'd just assumed she'd trained mages before.

"Yup. I might be respected, but that doesn't mean the higher-ups think I'm responsible, so I never got any of the trainees with real talent. Neil was a necromancer, strike one, who'd already messed up and gotten busted, strike two, and was considered to have a 'bad attitude,' which made strike three. Nobody wanted him, which was why I was able to swing in and scoop him up. In a few decades, when he's got his shit sorted out and his powers under control, there are going to be a lot of mages pissed they didn't take the chance to train him when they had it. That kid is going places."

"In a few decades, you might be, too." I slipped from the limo and extended my hand, helping Amy down from the high perch. "Cyndi's right, you do tend to jump in and help when the need arises. Maybe you are suited for mage politics."

Amy's face scrunched in disgust and her hair . . . hissed at me. She shut the door, grabbing her bag and handing me my suitcase before she did. "Mages live a long time, and a lot changes during our lives, but I don't see me going down the same path as Cyndi no matter how old I get. Time will tell, I guess."

We crunched along through the parking lot, toward the warm glow of Charlotte Manor's porch lights. "Just because you pick the same job as her doesn't mean you have to do it the same way. I'm sure there are lots of ways to be a grand mage. Maybe you could be obsessed with seventies music and wear lots of tie-dye."

"With how many drugs I do? *Way* too on the nose." Amy laughed,

and her hair waved in what—and bear in mind, I am purely guessing—seemed like a cheerful manner. “But thanks, I’ll think on that idea. Tomorrow, though. Right now, I am ready to rest and relax.”

“You and me both.” I pulled the front door open to find not only Charlotte waiting there, which she usually was, but also Krystal and Arch in the middle of what looked like a heated discussion. The moment we entered, all eyes turned in our direction and Arch stepped toward me.

“Good, you’re already packed. We’re running behind and need to head out now.”

“Like hell he does,” Krystal snapped. “He’s an accountant; he’s not going to an active field site.”

“It’s never non-active and you know it, but that doesn’t change the fact that inventory and cost assessments are part of the bargain,” Arch replied. “Fred, if you need to refill your blood flask or get anything from your room, you have five minutes to do so. After that, we’re heading out. The Agency sent down orders this morning, you’re going to do a full work-up of one of our more . . . bustling field locations.” He patted me on the shoulder lightly, in what I think was a gesture of reassurance.

“And if you have any body armor, you might want to pack that as well.”

## **An Inventory in the Base**



1.

There was no limo or teleportation door this time, just a black SUV that I suspected was armored, an unnamed driver with a stoic expression, and a trek to the same airport we'd visited when I was going for my Agency interview. Despite the fact that I was worn out, curious, and more than a little anxious about where we were heading, it was hard not to wonder about these drivers everyone kept using. Were they a service parahumans could call on, like a secure ride-share, or did everyone employ their own drivers to haul people around in various fleets? Maybe they were like interns, working their way up each organization's respective ladder, although I'd never seen anyone with such deadpan expressions in the higher roles of any parahuman outfit. It was a question I meant to ask Arch about once we were safely on the plane and out of earshot, but no sooner had we gotten aboard and begun to taxi down the runway than Arch started to speak, and given the subject matter, there was no way I was going to cut him off.

"I know you've done a little work for the Agency already. The trip to the castle, and of course, all the digital tasks they've been sending your way to take care of remotely. This isn't going to be like any of that, not even the castle. Where we're going, there is serious danger. It's a base used by active agents whose location is fairly well-known. They're a boots-to-ground, first response team for their area. We don't employ these very often, mind you, but sometimes a lot of chaos all gathers in one city, and having agents constantly around becomes a necessity. So I need you to understand that there is real danger in going to this place, and if I tell you do *anything*, you cooperate immediately. Before we move on, tell me you understand that."

"I understand perfectly," I said. Arch didn't look any more flustered or anxious than normal, which was about zero percent on any given day, but there was something heavy in his voice. This was serious, and he wanted to make sure I treated it that way.

"Good." Arch didn't relax, exactly—he never seemed to relax as far as I knew—but his tone did get a touch lighter. "Right now, no one is expecting there to be any issues. They've just put away an alchemist who was peddling parahuman potions to humans, so there should be a little time before anyone fills that power vacuum. But, as you can imagine, just because things *should* be peaceful doesn't mean they will be. Thankfully, you'll be exposed to minimal danger. All you need to do is check the inventory of the base's food, ammunition, fuel, and other basic supplies that have to be stocked in case of a siege. Compare it to what they were at last quarter's inventory, figure out how regularly orders need to go through, work out a budget . . . I think you've got the point."

I had. It wasn't a tough concept to understand in the first place.

However, there was something odd about it. “Arch, I made this deal with the Agency, and I’ll honor it, but what you’re asking me to do doesn’t really demand an accountant. Anyone with the ability to do basic math and maybe build a spreadsheet could knock this out no problem. What’s going on? Is this some kind of power play to show me the kinds of places the Agency can send me if I start pushing back on assignments?”

We had to pause our discussion as the engines flared to life, thundering in our ears as they strained to get us up from the ground and into the safety of the clouds. It dawned on me then that I still had no idea where we were even going, although that felt like the least of my problems in the moment.

Finally, the engines died down to a steady roar, and Arch was able to reply. “Maybe. I don’t know for sure what’s going on. This stunk to me too, so I tried to shake out a little information before you arrived. All I was able to suss out is that the order to send you over didn’t come from Roderick. It was higher on the chain of command, high enough that no one was giving me a straight answer. That’s why I decided to tag along.”

“Wait, you weren’t assigned to transport me?” I asked.

“Fred, I know to you, it seems like I don’t do much when I’m at Charlotte Manor, but trust me when I say they don’t have agents like me spend time being flight-buddies with freelance assets. No, I decided that if they were sending you out like this, then you’d at least have the courtesy of a bodyguard. Technically, I’m doing a spot-visit on the base to see how the team is holding together, but I’m going to be at your side the whole time, just in case.”

“Thank you for that, sincerely. I’m honestly amazed Krystal didn’t storm onto the flight as well.” When I’d kissed her goodbye, Krystal had looked like she was ready to pistol-whip the first person who looked at her sideways, but she’d let us leave. Evidently, even she had some orders she couldn’t refuse.

Systematically, Arch pulled guns out from under his coat, checking the sights and clips in each one. “Oh, she would have if I didn’t, no matter what the brass up top said. But she doesn’t have the seniority I do. She can’t just start shoving her way onto missions whenever she feels like it. Not without cause, anyway. Besides, I have an in with this group. I used to be part of it.”

“I thought you did training,” I recalled.

“I do whatever I like in between times when they really need me,” Arch replied. “For a while now, it’s been teaching. Before Albert came along, I was helping to get this team up and running. They’re all good agents, mind you, but like most of our kind, they weren’t used to teamwork. I had to smooth out those wrinkles, although it didn’t take very long. By the time

Albert needed help, they were already running like a well-oiled machine.”

This time, I was the one who let the conversation lapse, and my reasons had nothing to do with the roar of the engines. Talk of Albert made me feel . . . actually, I wasn’t sure how to feel. The office wasn’t the same without him, and while we saw each other semi-often, it was almost always in passing. We both had jobs to do, and they demanded much of us. He looked happy, and I hoped he was. Part of me was afraid that the fleeting smiles I saw were an act, though. I’d pushed him into a new direction with his life, and in my heart, I was terrified by the idea that I’d steered him wrong.

“How is Albert’s training going, anyway?” I tried to be nonchalant about it, but from the way Arch half-rolled his eyes, I didn’t think it was a successful attempt.

“Good. He’s growing much faster now that we’ve got time to train properly.” Arch didn’t slow down his inspection of his guns as he spoke; if anything, he cleared through them faster.

“And is he happy?”

“Most days he is, although sometimes, he wishes he could go back to being an assistant.” If there was one thing I could count on Arch not to do, it was mince words. “He’s been handed a weapon of destiny, with all the duty and weight that entails. It’s a lot to bear, especially for a kid his age. Wanting to run from it is natural, so of course there are days when he feels like going backward. But in the end, this will be better for him. The thing about destiny is that it keeps on coming whether we like it or not. Thanks to you, when his arrives, he’ll at least be prepared to face it.”

I nodded, looking away from the guns and out the window to the night sky. “As long as he’s happy.”

“He will be, and he won’t be. Nobody gets a fully happy life all the time, and if you’re trying to lead your friends to one, then prepare for a lot of disappointment. Just listen to what they want, and try to remind them of that when they hit a crossroads. Good leaders point you toward the right path; they don’t drag you down it. Because if they did, it wouldn’t be your choice anymore, and that’s not leadership. It’s tyranny.” Arch finished cycling through his weapons and put the last one away, tucking it seamlessly under his jacket, where it became impossible to spot. “If we’re done talking about Albert, do you have anything else you want to know while we’ve got the downtime to talk?”

“Where we are going seems prudent,” I said. “And how long will we be there? I do have other clients and appointments, you know.”

“They checked with Lillian to make sure you were clear for three days, so I doubt it will be any longer than that. Like you said, it’s not a hard job, especially for someone as experienced as you. As for where, have you ever heard of Northview, Maine?”

I shook my head, since it didn't ring so much as a single bell.

"Yeah, didn't think you would have. Used to be a midsized town until they created a big incentive program to get businesses to build their headquarters within city limits. Tax breaks, cheap land, the works. It was effective. Lots of companies moved or started there, which brought jobs, money, people, and of course, parahumans. It's a new slice of metropolis, and every parahuman is scrambling to make sure they end up on top of the heap," Arch told me. "The agents' job is to ensure they do so within the confines of the treaties and don't get humans caught up in the turf-war."

The plane shook as we hit a patch of turbulence, and I buckled my seatbelt. "Sounds tough."

"It's the job agents sign up for." I noticed Arch didn't bother fastening his safety belt as he spoke. "But you didn't, so I'm going to do my best to make sure you don't get caught up in anything besides inventory. Remember: keep your head down, stay in the base, and do what I say at all times. Stick with that, and we should be fine."

I wasn't sure if Arch was genuinely optimistic or lying to keep me calm, and he was too inscrutable to figure out which it was. Instead, I turned my head back to the window and looked up at the stars. Something told me this was going to be the last bit of peace I might get for a few days, so I'd better savor it while I could.

2.

When Arch had described the place we were heading as a “base,” I’d immediately pictured something heavily fortified, set well away from the general public, with spotlights and big chain-link metal fences around the perimeter. The failing there was on me, because in my curiosity, I’d allowed my imagination to run wild, forgetting the very real obligation agents had to get their work done while blending in with the rest of the human world. So of course their base wouldn’t stand out so overtly. Still, I felt like it was something of a stretch to call the rustic brown townhome near the center of a newly built downtown a “base.” The gate around the yard didn’t even come up past my waist, for goodness’ sake.

I was suitably more impressed a few seconds later, as we crossed onto the property and I felt the ethereal tickle of passing over a ward. I hadn’t been through many at that point in my life, but it wasn’t a sensation that was easy to forget. Almost like fingers running gently down your bones. We made it to the front door without issue, and Arch rang the bell. Loud footsteps raced from behind the door, followed quickly by the sound of something metal and heavy being moved. It took a few seconds—a few seconds where I felt oddly exposed given how suburban and pleasant my location seemed—before the door was flung open to reveal a large man with shaggy brown hair in a leather jacket.

Now, let me pause here, because I recognize that the word “large” has a somewhat shifting meaning in my social circles. This fellow was large by human standards, standing well past six feet tall, with broad shoulders and a muscular frame. It was adequate bulk to be intimidating, even if he would have paled in comparison to someone like Richard. Still, he was big enough that Arch seemed to disappear in the giant, wide-armed hug the man wrapped the smaller agent up in.

“We just got word that you were coming!” The larger man was squeezing so hard I wondered if Arch would pop, or simply start shooting. I couldn’t remember anyone hugging Arch before, or at least not so freely as this. To my surprise, Arch didn’t fight back or object, he just let the hug run its course until he was set back down on his feet once more. Only then did the man in leather turn to me and extend a friendly hand. “You must be Mr. Fletcher. I’m Agent Persimmons, but everyone just calls me Wallace.”

I shook his hand, noting that the grip was firm, yet never veered into anything aggressive. “A pleasure to meet you, Wallace. Please, call me Fred. I’ve never been one to stand on formality, especially with friends of friends.”

“Oh, someone else willing to call this old curmudgeon a friend. Arch, you must be getting soft.” Wallace motioned for us to step inside, which we did as he shut the door behind us. As it turned out, the innocuous townhome

had metal walls all throughout the interior, with arcane symbols painted around every window and door in sight. Wallace had to shift several heavy bars back in place to fortify the front door, making it even harder to get through. This sort of set-up was probably a serious fire hazard in terms of easy exits, but it did make me feel less nervous about where I'd be spending my next few days.

Arch and I followed Wallace down the hallway as he spoke, visibly excited about the visit. "Harris is putting together a meal that should be done pretty soon, Paula and I were cleaning out your old room, and Marj is prepping a cot and cell for Fred. Sorry about that, by the way, but the cells are the only spare space we've got to put guests."

"Fred can have my old room. I've slept on plenty a prison cot in my day," Arch offered.

"A cot is fine. I plan to spend most of my time working, anyway," I replied. In a way, this was better. No comfort meant no distractions, which meant I could get the job done all the faster and we could go home. Amiable as Wallace was, I still had no desire to stay here any longer than needed.

We turned a corner, of which there were an odd amount in these halls, and nearly ran smack into another vampire. Unlike Wallace, she wasn't wearing anything leather and had normal human proportions. Dark pants, a gray shirt, and a pair of guns on her waist, she looked professional and collected. Our eyes locked, studying each other, until she smiled with more sincerity than I'd been expecting. No fangs in the grin either, which was a nice change of pace for new vampire meetings.

"Paula, this is the accountant that goes by Fred," Wallace said, making quick introductions. "He's the one the Agency sent for inventory."

"I read the memo, but I didn't believe it. So, you're the vampire who's been working as a freelance accountant, huh?" Her voice was gentle, yet I had no trouble making out her words. After the overt evil of Quinn, Petre's visible disdain, and Lillian's bombastic nature, it felt odd to meet a vampire that was so composed.

"I am indeed. Fredrick Frankford Fletcher; though, as Wallace said, please just call me Fred."

"And I'm Paula. Pleasure to make your acquaintance." She walked past me, to Arch, though she didn't wrap him in a hug like Wallace did. Instead, they just shook hands briefly before she smiled again. "Will you have time to face me while you're here? My accuracy has improved quite a bit since our last duel."

Arch didn't answer right away, which was unusual for him, but eventually he tipped his head forward in agreement. "As long as we hit the shooting range when Fred is working nearby, I don't think that will be any sort of conflict."

Paula smiled again, then continued down the hallway in the opposite direction. Quiet and to the point, now there was something I hadn't seen a lot of among parahumans. We kept walking, stepping into a kitchen where a man who looked like he was in his early twenties was racing about, various foods flying around him.

That's not hyperbolic language, by the way. Eggs, celery, carrots, and a whole chicken were wobbling through the air as this man ran between the stove, oven, and several mixing bowls on the counter. Occasionally, he'd reach up and snatch an ingredient from mid-air, tossing it into a bowl almost haphazardly before turning his attention elsewhere. Wallace tried coughing loudly several times to get his attention, but eventually, he gave up and spat out the cook's name. "Harris!"

"Huh? What? Ten more minutes!" Harris whirled around on us, a streak of flour on his cheek that I couldn't imagine he'd gotten through normal means. "Oh shit. Arch is here already?"

"I told you he was here when I ran past to get the door," Wallace said. There was exasperation in his voice, but the sort that was resolved to knowing that no amount of frustration would change the situation. This was clearly Harris at his usual, and as a teammate, Wallace had made peace with that a long time ago. "And the vampire next to him is Fred. He's going to be doing inventory for the next few days, so try not to do any big runs on the food supply until he finishes."

"What, you want me to cook for our guests with what's in the fridge? You ask me to shame my pride as a chef." Harris defiantly put his hands on his hips and stared Wallace down. Before either of them could dig in for a long fight, Arch stepped forward and broke the tension.

"So, it's a chef these days, huh?" Arch turned to me, something almost like a smile on his face. "When I left, Harris was training to be a top-tier mixologist, and before that, I believe it was a sculptor, and before that—"

"I will not apologize for searching tirelessly to find my true calling," Harris snapped. His expression turned sheepish when he realized who he'd been short with, and the next time he spoke, it was with a more subdued tone. "Sorry, I get a little testy when I'm mid-recipe. You all head on down, I'll call you when the food is ready and I can have a more even-tempered conversation."

Wallace took the cue, leading us past Harris and the floating food to a set of stone steps leading downward, ones I was positive hadn't been part of the home's initial construction. Once we were on the stairway, Arch leaned into me and whispered, "Harris is a great caster, a prodigy with the makings of an eventual archmage. But he says too much magic on the brain can make your mind stagnant, so he's always trying to master new hobbies as distractions. It's a pain, but it *does* seem to make him better at magic, so we

all learned to put up with it.”

It hadn't escaped my notice that we were barely through the door and Arch was already lumping himself in with the rest of the group. I wondered how long he'd spent working with them, and why he'd been so ready to leave a place he clearly felt at home. Was Albert really important enough to have left somewhere like this behind?

The stairs went on for a while, as we passed several floors and still kept descending. When we finally stopped, it was because the stairs had as well. They went down no further than the floor we were on. Stone was all around us—I was certain that this area *definitely* wasn't on any permits at city hall—and more arcane symbols dotted the walls at regular intervals. Wallace took us down a short hallway to a large open area with several doorways.

“To the left is our makeshift jail. It isn't very nice, but we've got one cell without silver bars at least, so that's where you'll be staying, Fred. Up ahead are the training rooms, and one of our ammo storage areas. It seemed like a bad idea to store all the guns and ammo in one place, especially near the jail, so there's a few rooms through the house you'll need to visit to do a full inventory. On the right, however, is pretty much all of our goods that aren't dangerous. Food, toiletries, water, flea shampoo, all the essentials.”

Even if I hadn't already suspected Wallace's nature as a therian, his comment about flea shampoo being an essential would have clued me in. A vampire, a mage, and a therian—not a bad team, all things considered. But there was still one more person Wallace had mentioned that we'd yet to run into. As it turned out though, the door to the jail area opened right then, and a woman in jeans and an oversized sweater stepped out. I waited for an overt clue as to her nature, like I'd gotten from the others, but as she walked over, nothing jumped out at me. She seemed human to my senses, not that that really meant much. Krystal and Arch both read as human to me, and while I still had no idea what Arch was, I knew Krystal was anything but mundane.

“Arch, so good to see you again.” She was the first one since Wallace to greet Arch with a hug, and while it wasn't as strong or as enthusiastic, it was surprisingly tender. I was about to look away when they broke apart and she looked to me. “And you must be Fredrick Fletcher, the accountant who goes by Fred. I'm Marjorie, but everyone calls me Marj, and you should, too. It's a pleasure to meet you.”

We shook hands, and I studied her, trying to figure out what qualified her to be on a team of parahuman badasses. Still no hints, so I let the matter slide out of my mind. The parahuman world was a big one, and there were plenty of types I'd never even heard of, let alone met. No sense searching my mind for knowledge that wasn't there.

“Pleasure to meet you, as well,” I replied. “Do you all have a particular order you'd prefer I handle the job in? I'd like to cause as little



disruption to your work as possible.”

“If you could start with the food so Harris doesn’t pitch a fit about not being able to cook, that would make everyone’s life easier,” Wallace said. “After that, go in whatever order you like. We’re stood down for anything except emergencies while you do inventory, so we shouldn’t need much in the way of ammo.”

“Closest thing we have to a vacation.” Marj sounded oddly cheerful about the fact that they rarely got time off, but perhaps she was just happy because they were spending the downtime with an old friend. “Arch, you want a rundown of what’s been going on since you left?”

“I’m here to watch over Fred,” Arch said. “So we’d need to be somewhere close to him.”

“Why don’t you all have a meeting right here?” I suggested. “Wallace, if you can show me to the storage area with the food, I’ll get to work so that Harris can have free rein of his kitchen once more.”

“Bless you, Fred. I was not looking forward to fighting him over the next meal.” Wallace brought me to the door on the right and led me through.

Behind us, Arch and Marj were already deep in discussion, and I worked hard to tune them out. Whatever they were talking about, I probably didn’t have the clearance for it, and even if I did, I was almost certainly happier not knowing. With any luck, I could just do my job, he could have a nice visit, and we’d be back on the plane soon.

Even as I told myself that, however, I didn’t really believe it. While it would be nice to dismiss such feelings as intuition, the truth of the matter was more straightforward: I was finally learning to prepare for the unexpected. Not that any amount of bracing could have truly prepared me for what was to come.

3.

The first day went surprisingly smoothly. For all the emphasis Arch had put on being alert and prepared for anything, ultimately, it was a quiet patch of hours spent taking stock of the group's food and sundries. No one bothered me, except for Harris popping in repeatedly to ask if he could have access to the pantry once more, and even that stopped once I gave him permission. Curiously, he didn't actually take anything to cook once he could; he just smiled, grew visibly more relaxed, and left me alone. With mages, I was slowly learning there was a certain amount of peculiarity cooked into their personalities. I had no idea if it was a side effect of using magic, or whatever enabled them to accomplish such a feat in the first place, and I didn't spare much time trying to figure it out.

I was all about the job, forgoing sleep even after my watch told me we were into the daytime once more. True, I was a little tired, especially after the outing with Amy, but Arch wasn't a man to use hyperbole. If he thought the less time spent here, the better, then I'd sleep when I was safe in Charlotte Manor again. Besides, I'd gone far longer than a few days without sleep during the crunch of tax season. We were still well within my comfort zone, and I planned to be done before the lack of sleep could wear on me.

As for Arch, he was staying true to his word. Every time I popped a head out the door of the storage room to ask something, he was there. Sometimes alone, more often talking with one of the members of the group. They were always polite and quiet enough that I could tune them out, but it was plain that they wanted to spend as much time with their former member as possible. He seemed to be enjoying it too, which made me feel a bit guilty about how quickly I was racing through the job. However, since he'd been the one encouraging me to get this over with, I kept up the pace. If Arch wanted to change the plan, he'd have told me about it. The man was never shy about giving orders.

By the time the sun set once more, I'd finished logging the storage room's contents and had moved on to inventorying the nearby ammunition stockpile. If you're surprised that it took me so long to complete one room while working nonstop through a day, then you are severely underestimating how much they actually had on hand. I'd thought Wallace was just using a simple phrase to convey meaning when he mentioned a siege, but the truth was that they really were set-up to withstand a prolonged attack for weeks, if they had to. There was even an impressive blood storage system that I suspected was magical and meant to sustain Paula.

Through all the counting and calculating, however, the same thought kept nagging at me: this was simple, basic work. While I'm not above doing menial labor when needed, that didn't change the fact that this was a strange

use of my time. The Agency didn't own me outright—they could only force me to work so many hours in a given year, and *this* is how they were using a big chunk of them? It made no sense, which kept me searching for some other reason or explanation as I worked. Confidential materials they wouldn't trust to someone with less experience, or a convoluted tracking system that would take expertise to figure out, anything to explain why I'd been brought here. A whole day had passed though, and I'd come up empty, which should have made me more relaxed, but was instead only increasing my anxiety. Unseen complications were always more worrying than the ones you saw coming.

A polite knock on the door roused me from counting bullets, which is a chore that lends itself to taking any distraction possible, and I saw Paula step into the ammo room with a pair of coffee mugs. I didn't even need to sniff to know that they had blood inside them; the scent reached out and crammed itself into my senses instantly. Vampires were hardwired that way. I could tune out a lot of noise and smells when I put my mind to it, but blood cut past every line of mental defense I had and went right to the primal part of my brain.

"Evening, Fred," Paula greeted. "We thought you might want to take a break for some nourishment. Even Arch eats at least once a day." She extended one of the mugs to me, and I accepted. The blood was glorious—it always is, since the liquid lights up every part of a vampire's tongue and brain—and before I realized it, I'd drained half the cup. Apparently, I was hungrier than I'd realized.

"Thanks. Sometimes when I work, I tend to zone out and forget about basic necessities."

She snickered under her breath, explaining before I had a chance to ask about the laughter. "Sorry. It's just a little funny, you know? There's the old legend that if you throw seeds or small objects in front of a vampire, they'll compulsively count them without pause, and here I come down to find you so spaced out from counting bullets that you forgot to eat. Makes me wonder if maybe that's why they sent a vampire to do the inventory."

"Sadly, my tendencies toward tallying extended well back into my human life as well," I admitted. "Though I can't say I ever had occasion to count bullets. Unless you count bullet points, which you probably shouldn't."

Paula sipped from her mug and walked over, taking a look at the pages where I was keeping track. "You've gotten through a lot of stuff already. I'm impressed, but I guess I shouldn't be. Arch says this is your gig full time. I'd love to hear the story of how that happened."

"Not much to tell, I'm afraid." In retrospect, this sounds like I was being coy, but at the time, I really didn't feel like my story was particularly worth recounting. "My sire turned me because I was a socially anxious shut-in who was better with numbers than people, hoping that giving me this

power would let my ‘dark side’ out and I’d go on a killing spree. But with no one to teach me about parahumans, I just stuck to my old life. By the time I met another parahuman, I was sort of set in my ways again, so I found a way to bring my old life and my new life together.”

“Abandoned, huh? That’s a tough start. A lot of abandoned vampires don’t survive their first year. They draw the attention of agents or piss off the wrong people, or go crazy because they can’t accept what’s happened to them. I’m glad you made it through.” Paula was looking at me curiously, studying my face. She was probably checking for falsehoods, and I didn’t begrudge her that. Given her job, and that I was in their safe haven, it was natural to make sure I wasn’t concealing some wicked intentions.

I took another, more measured drink from my mug as I debated how to respond. It felt like she was fishing for something, but I didn’t know what. Since I had nothing to hide, I decided to barrel on as if I hadn’t noticed the scrutiny. “It was hard for a while, but thankfully I made some friends who taught me how this world works. How about you? How did you become an agent?”

Paula shrugged. “Was turned a few decades back. Didn’t mind the clan I was in at first, but eventually I wanted more for myself. Took a few years to train, and then applied to the Agency. Once they decided I had the right ethics and brain for the work, I got started. That’s pretty much it.”

It didn’t escape my notice that her story was really a few short points with as little detail as possible in between, though I didn’t raise the issue. Despite us both being vampires, we’d only just met, and it wasn’t polite to pry. Besides, it wasn’t as though I hadn’t skipped over quite a bit myself.

“Sometimes I wish I’d gotten the experience of getting taken in by a proper clan, other days I’m glad for the way things worked out. If I’d been educated by a vampire clan, especially one that would have had my sire as a member, I’m sure I would have inherited the old biases and fears toward other types of parahumans that they held. Instead, I got to make up my own mind about things, and I have more friends for it. In a way, I guess Quinn did me a favor abandoning—”

My words halted as the mug in Paula’s hand went tumbling down toward the floor. It never made it though, as she dropped and snatched it out of the air without spilling so much as a single drop. Sometimes I forgot just how powerful our kind was when we applied ourselves. Still, she didn’t exactly look steady as she stood back up, mug clutched firmly in hand. “Fred . . . did you say Quinn? As in, Quinn the one-armed vampire and former necromancer? That’s your sire?”

“He didn’t used to be one-armed,” I said, unsure of how else to really respond. “But then he messed with Krystal. Anyway, yes, Quinn is, or was, my sire. Why?”

“Because Quinn is one of the major players in Northview, a rat we’ve been trying to smoke out for months.” Paula downed the rest of her blood in a single gulp, then set the mug down on a nearby table. “That seems like a bit too much of a coincidence. If you’ll excuse me, I need to go talk to Wallace.”

As if he’d been waiting for the cue, we both heard the pounding footsteps of the group’s largest member barreling down the stairs. Frantic whispering sounded outside, and then the door swung open to reveal Wallace, looking far less composed than he had the last time I’d seen him.

“Paula! Gear up. That Ghoul Lord we’ve been searching for just showed his face on the other side of town, and he’s got a small army of lesser ghouls with him. Orders are to suppress as quickly as possible before civilians get hurt.”

Paula looked between Wallace and me for several seconds, then her eyes darted to Arch in the doorway. “You’re staying behind, I assume?”

“Do you really need me for something like that?” Arch countered.

“No, but I wanted to make sure Fred would have some backup, just in case.” Paula dashed past the door, yelling over her shoulder. “Give me two minutes to gear up, and I’ll be ready.”

“Fred, Arch, you two just keep at it,” Wallace said. “We should have this done in an hour or so, and be right back. Harris will seal the place tight, so nothing can get in, but that means you can’t get out either.”

“I’m aware of lockdown protocol.” Arch was checking his guns again, and this time, I was thankful for the ritual. If anything went awry, he was the only trained agent around. “I’ll explain it to Fred. You go deal with the Ghoul Lord.”

Wallace followed orders, dashing out the doorway and back to the stairs. From the speed at which he was ascending, I estimated it would be a few minutes at most before he and everyone else was out the door. I turned to Arch, noting the wary expression on his face.

“Do you expect any trouble?”

“As a rule, always,” Arch said. “But something that big happening—big enough to draw the entire team out with you on hand—makes me suspicious. From now until they return, you don’t leave my side no matter what, Fred. Is that understood?”

I nodded quickly. There was no way I planned on disobeying that order.

“Good, then get back to counting.” Arch pulled out a folding chair and set it so he was facing the doorway with his gun drawn. “There’s still work to be done.”

4.

Despite what you might expect, and certainly what I was prepared for, the door Arch was watching didn't suddenly get knocked in by a crew of evil parahumans. Instead, nothing happened, save for me tracking the sounds of the team getting into their cars and driving off. With no other way to occupy my time, I took Arch's advice and went back to counting bullets. In a way, I was glad for the task, as otherwise, I would have spent my time dwelling on all the possibilities of what might happen. There was one thing, however, that nagged at me, and eventually it grew so bothersome I couldn't even focus on my work anymore.

"Arch, did you know that Quinn was in Northview?" It was blunt, I'll admit, but conversations with Arch tended to work best when one got right to the point. Besides, we'd been through enough that I felt like we were friends, or at least amiable enough to skip some niceties.

"Of course. Krystal and I both get daily briefings about any activity that even slightly smells of Quinn," Arch told me. "He's the type to hold a grudge, so we're always trying to be ready in case he finally musters up the courage to come back to Winslow. His presence is why I insisted on coming along."

"Oh. Why not just tell me that on the plane, then?"

"Because I wasn't sure it would come up, and I didn't want you spending three days with that dangling overhead if it wasn't necessary. There was always the chance that this was a coincidence, after all. They do happen, even to parahumans." Arch's eyes and gun never wavered from the door as he spoke; his focus was unbreakable.

"You don't think so anymore, I take it?"

There was a long stretch of silence this time before Arch responded. "I think the Agency sending a useful resource to get a job done is a coincidence. But a big attack happening within a day of our arrival, one that leaves us alone in the house, that's a step too far. My money says someone was trying to smoke Quinn out and decided that you'd be bait he wouldn't pass up. They just didn't count on him being organized enough to put together this big of a distraction."

I was about to protest that the complexity of such a plan felt far-fetched, but then I remembered the last time I'd seen Quinn, in a church surrounded by ghouls under his control. He liked using ghouls as pawns, so turning them into a massive distraction fit his usual pattern. Arch was right; this was too much coincidence to brush off. "At least we're locked up in a fortress."

You might think that was the moment the door was kicked down, or a mighty explosion interrupted us, but you'd be wrong. Nothing happened for

several more minutes as I went back to work and kept counting bullets. When something did occur, it was more subtle than I'd been expecting, so much so that I almost didn't notice. Without warning, the lights in the room simply died, and as I strained my ears for the familiar hum of electricity, I heard nothing. Nothing except for faint footsteps from somewhere above us.

"They killed the power," I said. There was no point in pretending anymore; something was definitely going on, and given the number of footsteps, it was certainly a "they" situation. "I hear a lot of feet moving overhead, but I can't tell if they're in the house, or just on the property."

"If they aren't in now, they will be soon. Someone came here with a plan." To my surprise, Arch had left his chair and was digging through his coat. Rather than pulling out another gun, however, he produced a pair of glasses with runes along the rim and donned them. "Enchanted for night vision, plus I won't get blinded if someone throws a flash grenade. They're also next to impossible to knock off. This isn't my first time working in the dark."

It took me a second to realize that Arch was responding to the confusion on my face, which he could now see perfectly. In general, I considered myself a well-prepared person; however, I had nothing on Arch and his personal arsenal of weapons and tools. Just as I was preparing to grab some heavy equipment to bar the door, Arch walked over and carefully pulled it open.

"What are you doing?" My voice was barely above a hiss, yet it sounded so loud, too loud, in my vampiric ears.

"We can't stay down here. From what you said, it sounds like Quinn brought a whole team with him. They'll find us, and there's no way we could keep them out long enough to wait for our people to get back. Depending on the type of parahuman he brought, I might not be able to kill them all before they got to you. Better to stay on the move, give ourselves some options until the others return. But we're going to need a little help."

Arch dug into his coat once more, pulling out a dark leather bag. Reaching in, he scooped out a handful of dust and sprinkled it on himself before turning and blowing the rest of it around me. Some got up my nose, and I went to sneeze, but before I could, the sense of it had vanished. The bits around me were gone too, like they'd never been there. I took a test sniff and didn't smell anything. *Anything*. Not even the residual blood in the nearby mugs.

"Powder from the bones of a shadow-walker," Arch said, as if that somehow served as an explanation. "They won't be able to smell or hear us unless they're very close. It's how I sneak up on vampires, therians, and other parahumans with enhanced senses."

While I was a bit miffed at the sudden onset of anosmia, I did have to

admit that having such a material on hand was pretty . . . well, cool. I'd seen Arch in his role of authoritative leader, and I'd heard other agents talk about how respected he was, but this was the first time I'd ever seen Arch really on the job. He was composed, quick-thinking, and seemingly had a plan and tool for any situation. I just hoped he continued to live up to the hype once we actually met our attackers.

Slipping out of the ammo storage room, I strained my ears to hear the sounds of movement, but apparently the shadow-walker dust cut both ways. I could still hear, mind you, it was just that the amount I could hear was highly diminished. For that matter, when I *really* tried, I could pick up occasional smells from around me, though nothing like what I could normally detect. It took a few moments for me to realize what Arch's dust had done: he'd dialed back my smell and hearing to human levels. Disconcerting as it was, things only seemed so silent when compared with my normal hearing capacity. I wondered if I could buy some of that powder for nights when I wanted to work and the neighbors were being loud.

"Wait," I told him, my eyes catching a door to another room. "What about the jail cells? They said most of the bars were silver, right? We could hide out in one of those. Even if Quinn finds us, he wouldn't be able to get through."

"It's not a terrible plan, and if everything goes to shit, use it, but you can still shoot a lot of things through bars. Better not to leave you at his mercy if we can avoid it. Now, come on. I can hear them working on the door."

"Really? How? You got hit with the dust, too," I pointed out.

"Fred, my hearing is always at a human level. I've just spent a lot of time learning how to get the most out of that. Now, do you want to stand here gabbing, or do you want to get a fucking move on?" Arch stood there, unmoving, waiting for me to respond.

"Sorry. Lead the way." I fell in directly behind him, and as soon as I did, Arch began moving forward once more.

We crept up the stairs, Arch stopping occasionally to cock his head and listen as we ascended. I had no idea where we were heading; however, Arch never hesitated. He knew this place, after all, and apparently, time away hadn't dulled his memory in the slightest. Bit by bit, we rose, until we were almost back at the top floor. It was there that I heard the first sound from our attackers since Arch had coated me in dust, and it wasn't because the effects were fading.

The loud bang that echoed through the house and into its subterranean catacombs was impossible to mistake for anything other than what it clearly was: the massive, metal front door being roughly broken through. Arch and I looked at each other, though we said nothing. There wasn't a point in speaking the words out loud; we both knew what had just



happened.

Our attackers had broken through the front door. They were now officially in the house with us.

5.

Had I been on my own, I would have most likely frozen in panic until I was inevitably discovered by the intruders. Thankfully, Arch had no such reticence. No sooner had the noise started to fade than we were on the move again, past the kitchen and into the one of the bedrooms. It seemed counter-intuitive to me that we were moving closer to the people breaking in, but this wasn't really the time to question Arch's judgment. Especially since we were within earshot of the others, vampire hearing or not. I could make out the sounds of them scrabbling inside, and just before Arch eased the bedroom door shut, a familiar voice rang out—one that conjured terrible memories of a ghoulish church and Krystal with a bloody throat.

"All of you by the couch, go to the kitchen and head downstairs. Start at the bottom and search a floor at a time. If I know my spawn, he'll have holed up in the darkest corner he can find and be cowering in it. The rest of you, start working from the top down. Except you, Beauregard. You guard the front door." Quinn's voice was unmistakable, still as mad as it had been the last time. Except there was *something* different, even if I couldn't put my finger on what. His words seemed stronger, heavier, like there was an air of authority with every inflection.

Also . . . he'd just called someone Beauregard. That was a hell of a coincidence, seeing as Krystal had turned his old lackey with that name into sliced-up ashes. Did Quinn seek out underlings with that name? It was a weird detail, one I really didn't have time to dwell on, but it's amazing the things a mind will latch on to in a state of panic.

Through it all, Arch was silent, listening to the sounds of footsteps moving to various parts of the base. I could make out some, though not in much detail, but apparently he had a far better sense of their location than I did. Pulling out a dark gun in one hand and a gleaming silver dagger in the other, Arch tilted his head toward the door and whispered. "Four of them are still up here, not including the big one by the door. I can't tell which one is Quinn, but he might be among them, so be ready for anything if he pops up. Our best bet is to avoid the five up here, or kill them if they see us, and sneak out the front while the rest are searching below."

"Won't all of them come running the first time you shoot that?" I pointed to his gun, in case he'd missed the context.

Arch double-checked the weapon before shaking his head. "No, I pulled the enchanted one. Between the muffling spells and the shadow-walker powder, they shouldn't hear it. Trust me, Fred. I'm used to getting the drop on bigger, stronger enemies."

Not for the first time, I found myself wondering just what exactly Arch was. I knew he'd been alive for a long time, yet that was literally the

only supernatural feature he'd demonstrated, unless one considered constant calm a parahuman power. Which, given how impossible such a skill was for me to grasp, it might as well have been.

"We're going to have to move now. I can't risk leaving you on your own," Arch continued. "No matter what happens out there, don't worry about me. If I get hurt, pay no mind. Unless someone manages to shoot or stab me in the brain. Then, run like hell and just survive until help arrives."

I realize I've just commented about Arch's calm demeanor, but I was still bowled over as he placidly discussed the idea of his being shot in the head. There was no time to ponder it though, as he pushed open the bedroom door and led us out into the hallway, gun first. Arch was methodical, checking every corner we encountered as we took a route that felt circuitous, but that was probably picked to maximize our chances of making it out while encountering as few intruders as possible.

It was a good method, until we were halfway down a hall and another vampire stepped into view. There was no question of what this man was; his fangs were bared already, and they only continued to stretch further as we stepped into view. Yet there was something off about him as well. He moved more like an animal than a person, and dark, pulsing red lines stretched across the sclera of his eyes and into the iris. That was all the detail I could take in before a soft *pop* came from Arch, and the vampire's head whipped back. He was right; the gun really didn't make much noise. I stood, ready for my fellow undead to rise up; bullets weren't the best method of stopping us, yet he stayed on the ground, a small pool of dark blood stretching out around what remained of the back of his head.

Much as I'd have loved to back away, this was still the direction we were heading, so I had to press on. As we made our way past the vampire's body, because that's all it was now, I saw that the back of his head looked like a cannonball had soared out of it, and I caught the distinct glimmer of silver. I'm not quite sure why I'd never realized that agents, especially ones as prepared as Arch, would have bullets specially made for vampires, but it was still disconcerting to see the results laid out upon the ground. So much destruction from one shot; it boggled the mind. And Arch hadn't even hesitated. He'd fired without pause directly into the skull. Moments like these showed me why so many parahumans were afraid of agents.

Eventually, we made it past the corpse, although I wasn't sure it was a sight that would ever entirely leave me. As of the writing of these pages, it still hasn't, but plenty more terrible images have been added to keep it company. Arch slunk down the halls, always listening and at the ready for another attack. Whether it was luck or his guidance, I don't know, but we managed to make it to the living room where the front door was located without encountering another attacker. That, however, was where our luck ran

out.

Arch's elbow dug into my ribs as he pointed at a mirror on the wall, one that had clearly been placed to check the entryway covertly. The hulking monster in the doorway would have caused me to gasp audibly if I hadn't stopped breathing to stay quiet. It was a vampire—at least, I thought it was—but I couldn't even imagine the cocktail of blood it had been fed to assume such an appearance. Standing so tall his head brushed the doorway, the man was as wide as Bubba, but with a physique more akin to Richard's. His fangs were exposed, shining in the moonlight, as were the black claws on his hands and six horns lining his bare skull. Instead of the usual pale skin our kind had, this vampire—presumably the new Beauregard—had a complexion mottled with splotches of red, purple, and green. Beyond that, his skin's shape was wrong; it had odd lumps and dips, like poorly molded clay. The eyes, however, were similar to the ones we'd seen in our first fight, if one can even call it that—red lines across the sclera, just like the dead vampire in the hall. The rest of him was so bizarre that I wasn't even sure Beauregard counted as a vampire anymore. Quinn had done a real number on him, just like he'd do to me if given the chance.

Arch was stepping closer, getting ready to attack the behemoth blocking the door, when his eyes suddenly darted to a nearby doorway in the hall. Seconds later, a vampire woman with the same unnatural eyes—even by our standards—came bursting through. No sooner had she entered our view than Arch struck, slicing her with his blade. Unfortunately, she was quicker than the first guy, throwing up her arm to block and letting out a pained shriek as his dagger cleaved easily into her flesh. The pain caused her to pause, unsure of what to do next, and that was all Arch needed. Another *pop*, and she was down. Mercifully, the small hole in her forehead was all I could see this time. But dead or not, the damage was already done. Her yelp hadn't been muffled like our actions, and in the mirror, I could already see Beauregard rushing forward.

What I didn't see, however, was the vampire sneaking up behind me. No, Arch was the one who caught that, grabbing me by the arm and shoving me roughly to the side as he fired into its chest. The wounds were enough to slow it down, and Arch finished it off with another shot to the brain, but by the time he turned back, Beauregard had already arrived. One deft slap from Beauregard's massive paw of a hand sent Arch slamming into the wall. I suspect that if the whole place hadn't been reinforced, he'd have gone through it, but I could still hear the crunch of bone when Arch hit.

With him cleared out of the way, Beauregard advanced on me. There was no joy or surprise in his face; it was empty of any such higher brain functions. He was like a caged wolf being let loose on its prey, just a wild beast doing its master's bidding. God . . . what had Quinn done to these

people?

Before Beauregard could snatch me up and rip me in two, however, more muffled gunshots rang out. The mighty vampire looked pained, but he didn't drop to the ground. Instead, he spun in place to face his attacker. Arch was standing there, popping in a fresh clip, looking annoyed that his bullets weren't doing their usual damage. This time, I was the one who saw someone creeping up behind him, a familiar form that I pointed to while trying to get my friend's attention. "Arch!"

He started to spin around, just as the blade cleaved through his neck, separating Arch's head from his body in a single smooth motion. The body fell to the ground, but the head seemed to float for a moment. It took me a second to realize that, just like Paula and the mug earlier, Arch's attacker had caught his head before it could drop. Even one-handed, Quinn still had exceptional reflexes.

"Silly little agent. Did you think I'd learned nothing from tangling with your kind? *This* Beauregard is testing implanted subdermal armor for me. Magic might not be able to stop silver, but humans are remarkably adept at finding ways to keep their pathetic flesh-vessels safe." Quinn stepped fully into view, his left—and only—hand holding a long saber in the palm, his fingers wrapped around Arch's hair. Aside from the missing arm, he looked just as I remembered him, with the exception of the black collar with glowing runes wrapped around his throat. He grinned at me briefly, that smile promising all manner of suffering, before turning his attention back to Arch's head. "Funny how we endure for a few moments even post-decapitation. You'll be dead in seconds, so if you have anything to say to my spawn, I'd do so now."

I looked into Arch's eyes, from which the light was fading quickly, and noticed that he moved his lips silently, squeezing out a single word before his face went slack.

*"Run."*

6.

I did as I was told. I'm not proud of it, by any means. I dearly wish I could tell you that I was filled with righteous anger and that I rose up to stop Quinn and Beauregard right there, but if I had, then I wouldn't be writing this. That would be where my story ended, because they'd have easily overpowered me and, if I was lucky, killed me on the spot. No, I didn't find some hidden reserve of senseless bravery. Instead, I did what all humans, undead or not, have been hardwired to do since the beginning of dawn. I tried to survive.

Bolting back down the hallway, I did some quick mental math. Arch had said there were five vampires on the top floor, counting Beauregard. Between the three he'd killed and Quinn, that meant there shouldn't be anyone standing between me and the kitchen. Granted, I'd be plunging into floors with unknown amounts of vampires waiting for me, but there was at least a chance I could lose Quinn. With the time Arch had bought us, and the shadow-walker dust making me hard to find, I might be able to last long enough for the other agents to get back. I couldn't bring Arch back; however, I could still testify and make sure Quinn paid for the murder. That thought almost slowed me down; the grief at seeing a friend slaughtered made me want to fall over and weep. Survival is a powerful instinct though, and it wouldn't let me process the loss until I was safe.

Making it to the kitchen was easy. So easy, I felt a bit suspicious, not that I'd had any other options in the first place. With a giant, bulletproof uber-vampire blocking the front door, it was going to take someone with real strength to break through. All I had was a knack for numbers and a sweater vest. I bolted down the stairs as fast as I dared, making a break for the bottom floor. If I was lucky, which seemed unlikely, the first team would have finished searching it already, and I could hide out there for a while. Maybe I'd even be able to get into one of the jail cells with the silver bars. That probably wouldn't stop Quinn, but it might slow him down. At this point, I was playing a game of minutes, perhaps even seconds, where every bit of time I bought could be the difference between survival and death.

I made it to the bottom floor so fast it was a blur, leaping off the stairs and racing toward the cells. I managed exactly three steps before the vampires fell upon me from the shadows. Their grips were incredible. If they hadn't been drinking therian blood, then I didn't want to know what gave them this strength. They yanked me to the center of the room. Four of them had been here, had been *waiting* for me, with one grabbing each limb. I tried to prepare myself to be quartered, by which I mean that panic gave way to momentary acceptance of my fate.

Curiously, my life didn't flash before my eyes, as I'd always heard it would. Instead, my mind filled with images of the people I loved. Krystal,

Bubba, Amy, Neil, Albert, Charlotte, Richard, Sally, Lillian, and even curmudgeonly Arch. My clan. My family. I hoped they'd be okay when I was gone. I hoped the death of a leader didn't hurt the clan. I should have looked into that. I should have done a lot of things differently. It was oddly clear, here at the end. I could see now all the places where I'd been letting my fears and insecurities hold me back. One of life's cruel jokes, I suppose, that only in the moments before death do we see our lives plainly.

Except . . . they weren't ripping me apart. The other vampires, all with the same sclera-tainted eyes, had dragged me to the middle of the room and were holding me still. It didn't take me long to realize why, as footsteps came from the stairs. Slowly, Quinn stepped into view, sword in hand and evil smile on his face. He walked across the ground slowly, savoring the moment as he stared at my captured body.

"You are not an easy man to get to, Fredrick Fletcher. It seems the longer I leave you alone, the more connections you make. Once the dragon liked you, I nearly gave up hope of ever setting eyes on you again, but then you turn up here, in my backyard, staying in a house I was already preparing to infiltrate. Truly, the gods smiled upon me this day."

"If it was this hard for you to catch an accountant, you might be losing your touch." I would like to claim this defiance as bravery; however, in truth, it was simply terror worming its way out. With the certainty of death gone, I'd realized that Quinn was capable of doing far worse than ending me, and my panic had returned. All I could think was to buy time, keep him talking, wait for someone to arrive. It was a poor plan, admittedly, yet it was all I had to keep me going.

"I see your bitch's rudeness has been rubbing off on you." Quinn smirked as I struggled against the other vampires. If they'd let me go, I doubt I could have done anything, but something still compelled me to try after he spoke about Krystal like that. "Oh, Fredrick, defiant as always. Why couldn't you just do what you were supposed to and go on a murder spree? I had so many plans to put into place while you were drawing the agents' attention. Do you even know how many people like you I had to kill before one of you finally turned? And of course, it was you, the one who wanted to play nice."

"Wait . . . what do you mean, people like me? There were others?" It was not the most salient piece of the discussion, I'll own up to that, but it served the purpose of keeping him talking. Besides, I wanted to know what the hell he was talking about. It's human nature to be curious about our origins, after all.

Quinn laughed, and as he did, the other vampires seemed to shake, like they were chuckling as well, though no sound escaped their snarled lips. "Oh my, have none of your dear friends told you yet? Turning a human into a vampire is a difficult, imprecise process. No one is ever entirely sure why.

Some believe it to be a curse placed on our kind to keep us from growing our numbers too fast. Generally speaking, only about one in every hundred people will actually turn into a vampire when properly drained and fed. The rest simply die.”

I looked away from Quinn for the first time, glancing at the four vampires still holding me still. One in a hundred didn’t mean he’d had to kill four hundred to make them, I understood statistics well enough to know that, but it did mean he’d probably killed a lot of people to form this little army of his.

“You like them? I had to work my way through quite a few transients and drifters to shore up my ranks without catching the Agency’s attention. Although, I will say this, Fredrick, you were a lesson for me. I no longer trust my spawn to act properly on their own. That’s why I took some time off to acquire the lovely accessory around my neck.” Quinn stepped closer, and as he did, I could see red lines running between the runes on his necklace, just like the ones in the vampires’ eyes. “Sires naturally have some control over their creations, you see, but those with strong wills can fight it. While I hardly expected you to qualify, it was a lesson worth learning. No longer do I take chances. Instead, this useful tool exponentially increases my control over my spawn. They follow my orders perfectly, even if I’m not in earshot. That’s why they were waiting for you, by the way, and why they work as such a well-oiled machine.”

A few moment’s prior, I’d thought death was scary, but the idea of having my willpower stripped away and being forced to serve Quinn as a mindless puppet . . . that was a whole other level of terrifying. Quinn seemed to drink in my fear, grinning wider as he sheathed his sword and stepped closer.

“I’m sure you were hoping to stretch this talk indefinitely so that help would arrive, but I’m afraid I’m going to have to cut this short, Fredrick,” Quinn said. “For a long time, I dreamed about killing you as payback for what you cost me, but ultimately, I decided against it. That’s too quick for you and your little clan. No, I think instead, you’re going to be found, wounded yet alive, and brought home. Once there, you’ll be the one to start killing off those friends of yours. One by one, until eventually, the bitch who took my arm is forced to put you down. Now *that* feels like a more appropriate punishment, don’t you think?”

Quinn’s hand gripped my chin, pulling my gaze upward until our eyes locked. Too late, I realized what he was doing and tried to shut them, but the powerful hands from my captors lifted my eyelids. His gaze burned into mine, and the collar glowed brighter. “Don’t worry, I only need eye contact the first time. After this, you’ll do what I say whenever I say it. You, Fredrick, are finally going to be the obedient, useful spawn you were always meant to



be.” The collar brightened even more, to the point where it was hurting my eyes to look upon it. I’d have blinked the pain away if I could have, but instead, I tried to ignore it. Whatever he was doing, I needed to fight it. I needed to stay in control. I couldn’t . . . couldn’t let myself be a puppet. Especially not one he might use to hurt my friends.

“Hear me well, Fredrick, spawn of Quinn,” he said, voice low and heavy. The collar flashed, so bright I couldn’t see anything else. It felt like my eyes were going to burn in their sockets. “Hear me, and *obey*.”

7.

***\*\*Author's Note: While I was running from Quinn, there were quite a few significant events going on overhead, so I'm going to pass things off to someone who was actually there to tell what happened.\*\****

Every time I die, I have the same dream. Maybe it's a memory, but so many years have passed that I can't recall what the moment was truly like anymore. All I have is the dream that haunts me in the fleeting instants of death. She's there, of course. Lying on the ground, body shriveled and weak. Still beautiful, though. No matter how much time passes, no matter what happens between us, I'll always remember her as she was then, a perfect vision of kind, gentle loveliness. Were it just her, it might be a nice dream, even in the context of that particular moment. But it's not just her. I'm there too, and so is *it*. Dark wings spreading like dusk, gleaming eyes staring down at me, the scent of cinders and sulfur filling the air. I reach out to take one of its clawed, yet surprisingly graceful hands. A handshake. Such a simple gesture, with so much power behind it. Just as I take grip of those slender fingers, she looks up at the two of us from the ground and starts to cry out.

"Don't! Please, don't do this Arch—"

And then, as they always have since that day, my eyes snap open. Decapitation is a son of a bitch. Most wounds, I can shake off, they've self-repaired before I can fully notice them, but losing connection to the brain is another matter. Headshots and decapitation take me out of the action for a full ten seconds. If that doesn't seem like a long time to you, then I'm guessing you've never squared off against violent parahumans out for blood. Ten seconds is a lifetime, sometimes quite literally.

I didn't move. That lesson took me longer than I'm proud to admit, but eventually, I figured out that people ignore corpses. If I leapt up unprepared, Beauregard would rush me again, and I'd probably end up losing another ten seconds and starting right back on the ground again. Instead, I listened. There's an art to listening, to shutting out the world and yourself, focusing only on the certain sounds you want to track. It took me years to master, studying with some monks who'd dedicated lifetimes to it, but it was worth the effort. Besides, time is the one thing I have plenty of.

Beauregard was still nearby; he'd gone back to guarding the door, and had left my body in the hall. That was good luck for me; even someone that out of it would have noticed a head rejoining to its neck. Quinn had obviously done something to these vampires; the exact method he'd used was a mystery, but I got the general gist: he'd traded their intellect for stalwart obedience. He was hardly the first tyrant to do so, but it was a strategy that came with a lot of faults. Followers like that weren't soldiers, they were

fodder. Extra hands attached to one mind that couldn't properly control them all. The big vampire blocking the door was no exception. If he'd had access to his own brain, he might have swept the area occasionally instead of just standing in the open waiting for trouble to come to him.

Faintly, I could hear footsteps hurrying down the stairs, and another set going at a slower pace behind them. Good, if Fred was still running, then he wasn't dead yet. Had I dropped in a more covert place, I'd have taken off after him, but my legs sticking into the part of the hallway facing the remains of the front door meant that the moment I twitched, the brute would be on me again. Helping Fred meant taking Beauregard down first.

One of the few upsides of dying: people tend to talk more freely to someone they think is being swept off the game board. Quinn was nice enough to give away why my bullets didn't work: subdermal armor. I doubted it was anything sophisticated; given Beauregard's misshapen frame, it was probably just lumps of metal or other hard material surgically placed below the skin. The poor guy had clearly been the test subject for a lot of Quinn's "upgrades," so I needed to be ready for anything. I was going to have to kill him, and while I took no joy in offing someone under obvious mental control, some part of me suspected that if the real person in there could speak, they'd have begged me to end it for them. Maybe that was a fantasy I concocted to ease my conscience, but I doubt it. I've been an agent for loads of years, and I did other work before that. My conscience made peace with this sort of necessity a long time ago.

Carefully, I tested my hands and found my weapons still in them. The body naturally seizes up in death, so I'd long ago gotten into the habit of taking firm grips on my tools when I was slipping over. Habits were important, almost as important as training. I took a slow, steady breath as I lay on the floor, mentally picturing how the fight would go. I'd move, he'd charge again, and the next few seconds would be crucial. Beauregard was faster, stronger, and tougher than I was. But those were odds I was accustomed to facing. Fred's steps were getting fainter; he was probably near the bottom of the stairs. I needed to hurry.

In a single, near-silent maneuver, I rolled my legs overhead and flipped into a standing position. Some part of me hoped that maybe Beauregard would be looking away at that particular moment, but the sound of his lumbering stride said that my usual amount of luck (none) was holding strong. This time would be different, though. This time, I didn't have to try to protect a civilian *and* fight.

The walls snapped and cracked as Beauregard slammed into them, showing about as much grace as I expected from someone his size. He whirled around, reaching for my head, but I'd dropped into a crouch and darted forward. Pain was going to be my friend in this fight. My enemy was

irrational and incapable of complex thought, so the first step was to injure him and make him even more erratic. Without knowing where Quinn had shoved armor into the skin, I had to gamble that since Beauregard wasn't moving slow, he hadn't picked any spots that compromised maneuverability.

I pressed my gun's muzzle into the back of Beauregard's right knee and fired twice. Unlike when I went for the torso, these rounds went right through, expanding as they flew and nearly severing everything below the shin. I expected a howl of pain, but he barely grunted, even as he began to slump over. I guess Quinn knew that pain was easy to exploit as well, and had turned down Beauregard's sense of it. Inconvenient, yes, although it did mean no screams to alert Quinn that he was under attack again. Plus, Beauregard had lost the ability to maneuver, and that was really all the advantage I needed.

I kept my movement going, racing between his legs to the other side. Beauregard kept after me, spinning in place and tearing off more pieces of the already destroyed knee. He probably planned to snare me and drain me to repair the damage, but when he finished the turn, I was right there waiting for him. The gun was aiming down at his other knee, and even in his primal state, he understood the threat. Beauregard lunged for my right hand just as I'd hoped, leaving my left completely unattended.

Throats are another piece of the body it's hard to armor. Too many delicate pieces in there, even for vampires. A zombie might be one thing, but vampires live by drinking. Maybe one day, Quinn would find a way to reinforce that part of the body; he certainly seemed adept at this sort of horrible work. This experiment, however, was still vulnerable there, and I took full advantage of it. Slitting a vampire's throat won't actually do much, mind you, aside from annoy and momentarily injure them. Jamming a silver-composite blade through the throat and up into their brain is another matter entirely. My left hand finished the work before Beauregard could even lay a claw on my right, and he fell to the ground, heavy and limp.

I'll spare you all the gory details. Suffice it to say I quickly recovered my weapon and made sure Beauregard wouldn't be getting back up, then moved for the stairs. I could hear Quinn's voice; he was monologuing, and I found myself entirely unsurprised by that fact. It did give me some hope, however. If all he had brought with him were puppets, then that meant the only person worth talking to was Fred. All Fred had to do was keep him talking for a little longer, and I could get there to even things up. Quinn had gotten the drop on me before, I'm man enough to admit when I've been bested, but he'd find me a much tougher challenge when I didn't have to worry about a brute clawing my friend to death.

As much of a hurry as I was in, I still kept my pace steady and silent. Tipping Quinn off that reinforcements were coming wouldn't help anyone; it

might even get Fred killed. So I was quiet and careful as I descended, arriving at the bottom just in time to see Quinn grabbing Fred's chin while a pair of his flunkies yanked Fred's eyelids open. Whatever whammy he'd put on the others, he was about to put on Fred. I rushed forward, lifting my gun to aim just as Quinn was speaking.

“Hear me well, Fredrick, spawn of Quinn. Hear me, and *obey*.”

And just like that, I knew I was too late. See, it's like I told you. Sometimes, ten seconds is a lifetime.

8.

***\*\*Author's Note: Since Arch and I rejoined one another here, I'll resume the telling of the story from this point.\*\****

I felt the magic wash over me. It burned as it struck, not like standing in a fire, but like the soft, radiating pain of a sunburn. The sort of pain I'd never get to truly feel again. The sensation was quite unique, and hard to put into words. The best way I've found to describe it is that I could feel Quinn's will surrounding me, burning me, intent on replacing my own sense of agency. I readied myself to fight it, to mentally scratch and claw for all I was worth in order to retain my sense of self.

And then . . . it faded away. Whatever latch it was looking to unhook in my mind hadn't been there, and as the glow of the necklace faded, I noticed two things: a look of total shock on Quinn's face, and Arch running forward from the stairs with gun raised. Honestly, it was hard to say which was more surprising, since I'd left Arch as a headless corpse in the hallway, but it was an easy choice to see which one was more pertinent.

"Arch! The necklace! They're under Quinn's control, and he's using the necklace!" In hindsight, giving away Arch's approach wasn't the soundest tactical move, but since he'd somehow shrugged off a decapitation, I was far less worried about his health than that of the innocent vampires holding me.

Quinn whipped around, moving so fast even my enhanced vision failed to track him. I heard the dim *pop* of Arch's muffled shot, but instead of a sudden hole appearing in Quinn, there was a sound of metal hitting metal. In the span of a blink, he'd drawn his blade and deflected the bullet. What on earth had he been drinking?

"You survived? My, my, you are quite the resourceful one. I think I'll have to take a taste of you and see just what you're made of." Quinn didn't sound nearly as nervous as I'd have liked him to. And why would he? He had a vampire squadron at the ready to do his bidding; one word, and they'd drop me to swarm onto Arch. Which meant they'd die, and Quinn would either use the chance to murder me, or slip away again, killing four more innocent people in the process.

I couldn't let that happen. He'd already hurt so many, me included. What he'd taken from these people was something they could never get back, but it didn't have to be the end. I was proof that there could be life after Quinn—just not if he used Arch to off them. They'd already lost their lives once; they didn't deserve to have their second chance taken as well. I wished I could think of something to do. With my arms and legs held tightly, all I had to use was my mouth, and while I might be able to manage some light taunting, I'd never summon the wit to distract Quinn from an agent with a

gun. He was standing so close, too. If only I had one limb, one piece of my body to work with, I might be able to slow him down.

And then a memory flashed unbidden through my head, a snippet from the last time I'd had my entire body locked down like this—back at the high school reunion, when I'd been held on the shoulder of a werewolf/asshole. Maybe I wasn't so helpless after all. Quinn might have taken care of every one of my limbs, but he'd left me a vampire's most basic, powerful tool. With no time to think, I let the primal part of my brain do what it always wanted to do, what my kind were quite literally designed to do.

I bit. Specifically, I lurched forward and sank my fangs into the flesh of Quinn's left calf. Truth be told, after the last time we fought, and I failed to so much as even scratch him, I'd been prepared for my teeth to bounce off his flesh. Maybe he was drinking different parahumans these days, or maybe the fangs of a vampire have more piercing power than I realized. Whatever the case, they slid in easily, and I locked my jaw as fiercely as I could. This was a terrible position to be in. With my head extended, one swipe of that sword would slice through my neck as easily as it had Arch's, and I was pretty sure I wouldn't be getting back up from it. But it was a distraction, damn it, and it was the most I had to offer. All I could do was put my faith in Arch and hang on for dear life.

A lot of noises came quickly after that. Quinn yowled in pain, more *pops* from Arch's gun rang out, metal clanged as some shots were knocked away, and then . . . how do I put this? "Explosion" isn't quite the right word. It was more akin to getting hit with a massive blast of wind, only instead of air, it was light that buffeted into us—a blast of red light that tore out from Quinn and slammed into me and the other vampires so hard that it sent us hurtling into the wall, me with a chunk of Quinn's leg still in my mouth.

Vampires can generally take a lot of punishment unless there's silver involved, but I'll admit that my ribcage was rather rattled as I slowly pulled myself up after hitting the wall. I spat the bite of Quinn out—it was disgusting, and I'll do you the kindness of not trying to describe the taste—as I wobbled to my feet. My ears were ringing, and there were spots in front of my eyes that I tried to ignore as I scanned the room. This wasn't over yet; it wouldn't be until Quinn was captured or killed. I had to stay on guard until then, in case he decided to finish off his flunkies.

"He's gone." The voice came from over by the door to the cells, where Arch was standing calmly, lighting a cigarette. "After the collar broke, he started for you and the others, but changed his mind when I put a bullet in his uninjured leg. Instead, he made for the stairs right when I had to reload."

"So why didn't you chase him?"

"Because I didn't come here to catch or kill Quinn," Arch snapped, taking a long draw from his cigarette. "I promised Krystal I'd protect you."

Also, to be honest, I was kind of blind at the time.”

Now that brought me up short on whatever I was about to say. “Blind?”

“Yeah. Caught the light show full-force when the collar broke, and it burned out my eyes. They’re better now, thanks for asking. Though I will need some new enchanted glasses.” He nodded to the set of frames on the ground, which were smoking and crumpled.

“But you said you shot him in the leg,” I pointed out.

Arch let out a breath of smoke, like a short, gun-toting dragon. “I said I was blind, not deaf. Being able to shoot without vision comes up more than you’d think. Anyway, why don’t you go ahead and step on over here, Fred. I’d like a little space between you and the others before they shake that explosion off.”

Moans and squirming were coming from near me, but I made no move to leave my fellow vampires. “They’re not bad people. Quinn was controlling them with the collar.”

“Maybe. Or maybe he told you that so you’d let your guard down around them. Or they were bad people who signed on and then got whammied. Heck, maybe they’re starved and will attack the first thing they see. Point is, without knowing their situation, I can’t risk you being too close.”

Arch was raising valid points, and I knew that, despite my addled senses. All the same, I willfully ignored those points and reached down to grab the shoulder of the nearest vampire. It was a young man, probably not much older than Neil, who let out a small yelp at my touch. “Hey, hey, don’t worry. It’s going to be okay. Quinn’s gone now. You’re safe.”

For a few seconds (which probably weren’t that long, but that, in the moment, seemed to stretch on indefinitely), there was no response. Then, slowly, he tilted his head up and stared me in the eyes. The red lines reaching across his sclera were gone, although it looked like there were dark scars where the lines had been. “He’s . . . gone? You’re sure? What if he comes back? What if he calls to us again?”

“Quinn isn’t coming back tonight,” I assured him. “Quinn runs when he can’t win, and he can’t beat my friend over there. The artifact he used to control you is broken, too. It’s okay. You’re safe. I promise.”

The discussion pretty much ended there. Not because the vampire grew silent, mind you, but because he collapsed back to the ground and started weeping. I lifted my eyes from him to Arch, who had nearly finished his cigarette.

“It’s possible I may have been more worried than necessary.” He reached into his coat, but instead of pulling out a gun, he produced cell phone. I was tempted to ask where that had been earlier, but then I realized: who



would he have called? Even if they'd known about the trap, his old teammates would still have had to prioritize stopping a Ghoul Lord over protecting one vampire who already had an agent with him, and no one else would have been near enough to help. Arch clicked a few buttons, then held the receiver to his ear.

“Evening. I’m going to need a transport team with some counselors on board. We’ve got a batch of vampires that were turned and controlled. I imagine they’ll need a lot of therapy. Also, put me on Veronica’s books for a meeting next week. Someone just used my friend as bait, and I’m damn well going to know who.”

9.

Things happened quickly after Arch's phone call. The team came back, a few of them sporting small wounds and looking worn out, although that was nothing compared to the panic that hit them when they saw the state of their base. Arch calmed them down and explained things, though I wasn't around for the exact conversation. I kept myself planted on the lowest floor with the other vampires until help arrived. Part of me had been wondering what kind of counselors would show up; after all, the Agency seemed like a place where people were given a shot of whiskey and told to "walk it off" when trauma happened, but perhaps I'd underestimated them. It turned out that people being forcibly turned into different parahumans wasn't as uncommon as it should have been, and they had an entire department dedicated to helping people cope with the change.

None of the vampires had really recovered by the time the counselors came to take them somewhere more stable, and I didn't blame them. Being trapped under Quinn's control, having their bodies used like puppets . . . I couldn't even imagine what it would take to come back from that. One of them, however, did manage to tell me his name. Doug was the vampire I'd talked to earlier. He gave me his name just before leaving, and I handed him some of my business cards in case he or any of the others needed to talk. I didn't know if they'd call or not; maybe this was something they'd want to bury deep and never think about again. I just had to let them know I was around to listen if they needed it.

Once the vampires were gone and Arch was busy with his team, I did the only thing I could think to do: work. Well, that's not entirely true. First, I took an hour to do some research and reserve a few items online, then I got back to work. It was probably pointless—inventory didn't matter much for a base that might very well have to be abandoned, now that it was compromised—but I was determined to do my job. It was how I found peace in the chaos, and more importantly, I didn't want anyone at the Agency saying I'd shirked my duties. This was going to be a shitshow, I could see that already, and I wanted to offer little ammunition for whatever was coming.

Arch kept checking in on me regularly, and I had a long conversation with Krystal to let her know I was okay. She'd been shipped off to Seattle on assignment not long after we left—none of us thought that was a coincidence—but should be back by the time Arch and I wrapped things up. Wallace, Marj, Paula, and even Harris stopped by as well, each making small talk and checking on me without staying long. They meant well, and I knew it, but they'd lost touch with how to talk to people who didn't live in mortal peril constantly. They understood that the events had been hard for me, yet to them, it was really just any other workday. Aside from those visits, people mostly

left me alone. I think they were glad I put myself out of the way, as there were bigger issues for them to tackle, anyway.

It was nearly a day later when the door to the room I was in—the last room I was inventorying, in fact—slowly opened. This time, my visitor wasn't Arch, or one of the team. Instead, I found myself looking at the bald, pale head of Roderick. It was the first time I'd seen my DVA contact in person since the interview, though we had done a few video chats to work through particularly complex files.

"Glad to see you're looking well, Fred."

"You too, Roderick." It was a little more curt than I might normally have been, but given my feelings toward the Agency at that moment, it felt justified. I kept on task, counting up the shotgun shells the team stored by the case.

Roderick took a seat in one of the hard metal folding chairs and set his briefcase on the ground. "For what it's worth, and I know that won't be much, I tried to push back on sending you here. The danger was obvious, anyone could see that, and I didn't want to subject you to it. I'm sorry this happened."

"It's . . . okay. I've been in a company before. I know how powerless you feel when your bosses make poor choices you can't change." Bothered as I was by what had happened, it didn't make sense to take it out on Roderick. He was a cog in a machine; all he could do was turn in the direction he was ordered.

"Thanks. And if it helps, I think it's safe to say you're not going to be getting any assignments that are even remotely dangerous for a while," Roderick said. "This whole thing was a pretty big clusterfuck. People are pissed, and I don't just mean Arch. Gideon has filed a formal complaint that we willfully endangered your life, and I know that sounds like nothing, but when the King of the West complains, trust me—people listen."

"Gideon filed a complaint for me?" I was shocked, and not just by the fact that Gideon was capable of playing by the rules enough to do anything formally. I didn't think he'd care enough about me to make the effort.

"Well, officially his complaint was that, since you save his host money on taxes every year, and that money is often spent housing Gideon, by endangering your life, we were effectively robbing him." Roderick let out a long, weary sigh. "And dragons do not take being robbed lightly. It's been a long day."

Now *that* sounded more like the Gideon I knew. I was still touched by the gesture though, even if I suspected that the real motivation was that Sally liked me, so my death would trouble her. It was a kind act, regardless, and I made a mental note to write him a thank you card once I was home and

my bigger tasks were handled.

“Roderick, I don’t mean to be rude, I know you came a long way to have this meeting, but I’m nearly done with my job. Once it’s finished, I’m getting on a plane and going home, which I greatly look forward to. So if we could perhaps skip the small talk and pleasantries just this once, I’d really appreciate cutting to the heart of the matter.”

His egg-like head bobbed up and down in agreement as he lifted his briefcase and took some pages out. “You know the Agency has a reputation for being ruthless and scary, one I won’t deny is somewhat earned, but part of representing parahuman interests means owning up to and making amends for our failures when they happen. What happened here was a mistake, and no one is claiming differently. We put a useful freelance asset into an unstable field position knowing that a dangerous criminal would probably go after you. That’s wrong, and shitty, and someone is going to answer for it. But since we brought you back into the focus of a dangerous, wanted vampire, the least we can do is offer protection from here on out. You’re getting a bodyguard, Fred.”

“A bodyguard? Do you have enough agents that you can spare one to just follow me around? Also, and I think this is worth noting, I already spend most of my time in a magically fortified house with two other agents.”

“Bodyguarding is a different skill than being an agent, though sometimes our people retire into that job. We’ve got some sources we trust for this kind of work, and I’ve personally been selected to head the search. Krystal and Arch will both have to sign off on whoever I pick as well, just to make sure you get someone who can do the job.”

I finished counting the shotgun shells and made a brief notation on the paper. “I appreciate the gesture, but no thank you. I don’t think Quinn is going to come to Winslow anytime soon. Between the therians and Gideon, it’s not a safe place for him. If you want to give someone a bodyguard, give it to those four vampires he left behind. There’s no telling if he’ll come back for them.”

“The sentiment is noble, but it isn’t really up for discussion.” Roderick walked over and handed me the pages, none of which required a signature. I wasn’t being offered this; I was being told it was happening. “You’re important to several of our people, and you got handed a raw deal. Nobody is willing to risk that happening again anytime soon. Don’t worry about the other vampires, either. We’ve got programs for them, all Agency run. I promise, Quinn won’t get within a hundred miles of those four on our watch.”

I read over the documents Roderick had handed me. There wasn’t much to unpack; it was largely a breakdown of what my bodyguard would be accountable for and the tasks that could be assigned to them. Straightforward

and simple, a peace offering, though one I wasn't entirely sure was really directed at me. This whole bit felt more like I was a valued possession of someone important rather than important myself. I could have probably fought it if I wanted to, surely there were avenues available, but the truth of the matter is that I simply didn't care enough at that point. There were bigger things on my mind than the Agency saying they'd work to keep me out of danger.

"Fine. If Krystal and Arch are making the final selection, I guess it's okay. Just don't rush or anything, okay? I'd like to preserve my privacy for a little while longer."

"The selection process takes time," Roderick assured me. "And even when you have a bodyguard, they'll be adept at discretion."

I wasn't sure how much I believed that, but it was something to worry about another day. So long as the guard never got access to my clients' accounts, there wouldn't be much to fret over. It wasn't like I did anything worth spreading about as gossip, anyway. However, since I was giving in on the point, I decided to use my small bit of leverage. "Look, Roderick, I won't fight you on this, but I want you to do something for me. Keep me updated on how the other four vampires are doing. Nothing private; they deserve their own lives. Just let me know how they're getting along overall from time to time. And if they need anything, let me know. We abandoned vampires have to look out for one another."

"I think I can swing that," Roderick agreed. "But you're not really an abandoned vampire anymore, Fred. You have a clan."

"Doesn't change the fact that we all share the same horrible sire," I countered. "Just keep me in the loop. That's all I want."

"Consider it done." Roderick picked up his briefcase once more, putting the chair away before heading toward the door. "We've got a plane waiting for you whenever you're done here, or whenever you just want to leave. There are other people who can do this kind of work."

"Maybe so, but Fletcher Accounting Services doesn't leave its job's half-finished. Thanks for coming out, Roderick. Hopefully next time, we'll see each other under better circumstances."

Roderick took his leave, and I went back to the task at hand. The truth was, pride in my work wasn't the thing keeping me there. I just had time to kill, and I preferred to spend it doing something. If I sat around, I'd get in my head and probably talk myself into chickening out on what I still had to do.

Because as scary as the last few days had been, they were nowhere near as terrifying as the task waiting for me back in Colorado.

10.

“So, has anyone figured out why Quinn’s magic necklace didn’t work on you?” Krystal was holding my arm as we strolled through the park, a night of cloudless stars twinkling overhead. She and I had been almost, though not quite, inseparable since our respective returns to town. It was only thanks to the fact that she needed sleep that I’d been able run a single covert errand.

“No one seems to be sure, but the best idea I’ve heard so far is that it’s like my silver-immunity. Whatever changed in me when I channeled Gideon’s power broke the connection between sire and spawn that Quinn would have exploited. It’s just a theory, mind you. We’re still in uncharted territory.”

Krystal pulled me in a little closer, nuzzling her head against my shoulder. “At this point, I’m so comfortable in that realm, I’m not sure I could deal with actually knowing what’s going on. I still wish I could have been there to cap Quinn for good, though.”

It wasn’t the first time she’d expressed such a sentiment, and I didn’t expect it would be the last. Krystal was among the most powerful people I knew, which probably made it all the more frustrating when she couldn’t use that strength to protect the people she cared for. I suspected that, deep down, she felt guilty for not finding a way to tag along, ridiculous as that was. Her job was a serious one, and disobeying orders wasn’t something to do lightly. Given the circumstances, she’d done the best she could. I not only knew that, I appreciated it.

“Quinn is slippery; getting away is what he does best. In the end, it worked out okay.” Well, okay except for the vampires Arch had killed during the attack. Even knowing that it was unavoidable, the thought of so many innocent lives lost turned my stomach. I was trying hard not to dwell on it, but I’d begun to see their faces in my dreams. I didn’t know how Arch could handle the guilt; probably practice.

Together, Krystal and I walked along the park’s concrete path, winding through its grassy expanse. Despite the nice weather, we had the place pretty much to ourselves. That was one of the perks of being nocturnal: at three in the morning, there were precious few instances where I had to deal with crowds. Our walk continued in silence, over a bridge that crossed a small pond, where I could see ducks sleeping on the shore. It was nice, peaceful, a fine contrast to the busy townhome where I’d spent the last few days. On any other night, I’d have reveled in the ambiance, but that evening, I barely noticed. I was so anxious, it was taking all my focus to keep my hands from shaking.

“Hey . . . wait a minute. I know those tables and benches.” Krystal let go of my arm, pointing to a picnic area not far off from where we were

standing. “This is the park where we met Neil and Albert, isn’t it? Hoping to find another LARP group, Freddy?”

“No, having that experience once was more than enough,” I replied. “But I did realize that this was the park where we met them. It was our first real adventure-date, unless you count the high school reunion, which I decided not to for various reasons. Most important being that I didn’t think I could get you to go all the way back to Kent with me.”

Krystal turned from the benches, confusion and a touch of suspicion splashed across her face. “You’re not usually the overly nostalgic type, Freddy. Something going on?”

“Absolutely.” I stepped closer to her, absorbing every detail of the moment as best I could. Nearly being torn apart had made me realize how much I was taking for granted, and it was a lesson I was determined to learn from. “Krystal, during the attack, there was a moment where . . . where I was *sure* I was about to die. Not like the times when I’ve just been in danger. This was different. I knew, in the deepest part of my heart, that it was over, and I faced that truth because it was the only thing I could do. It was . . . well, not a pleasant moment, but an enlightening one. I saw things with a new clarity, especially where you were concerned.”

Her suspicion was quickly overtaking her confusion, her features starting to grow sharp and defensive. Given the way my words were coming out, I could hardly blame her. It was going about as smoothly as I’d expected, which was not very smooth at all. “Go on.”

“What I mean to say is that, for a long time, I’ve looked at this relationship with a short-term view. I figured that sooner or later, whatever attraction or need was keeping you with me would fade, and I’d go back to being on my own. You’re an agent, Krystal, and a great one at that. I’m just a guy who likes working with numbers. I could never see a real place for me in your life.” She was looking more and more bothered, so I kept going without pause. I had to get through all of this.

“Then, when I almost died, I realized how utterly idiotic that whole idea was. I’ve gotten to meet other agents, and I’ve finally realized that they aren’t mythical beings divorced from humanity. They’re just people. People with a lot of power, sure, but people trying to do their best, all the same. They have hobbies, and fears, and friends, and things they care about. Your job isn’t what’s going to end us. *I* am, if I keep letting my own insecurities and fears get in the way of what I know we both feel. And while I’ve made my peace with many forms of cowardice, that’s one that I cannot stand for.”

Krystal stared at me, the suspicion shifting back to confusion as she took my long, admittedly rambling, speech in. “I’m glad you’ve realized you’re not just some phase for me, Freddy, I really am, but I have to wonder where you’re going with this.”

In response, I took her wrist and slowly lowered one of my knees down to the concrete below us. My hand was fumbling, there was no stopping the shakes anymore, as it dug into my khakis and produced a small black box. Finding a ring had taken some care, but thankfully, most jewelry stores posted their wares online. Once I had one reserved, it had just been a matter of slipping out while she was asleep. I'd never been particularly adept at secrets or lying; however, some things were meant to be a surprise.

"Agent Krystal Jenkins, I love you with everything that I have, and everything that I am. You are the most amazing, exhilarating, terrifying, heroic, gentle, and loving creature, human or otherwise, that I've ever met. You're not just my best friend, you're my favorite person, and I want to spend however long our immortalities last at your side." I flipped the top of the box open, nearly dropping it, but somehow managing to hang on as the ring came into view. "Will you marry me?"

Krystal didn't answer so much as dive forward and tackle me the rest of the way to the ground, kissing me so hard it probably would have drawn blood from another person. We stayed like that for a time, embracing under the stars and the moon's soft spotlight. Finally, perhaps because it seemed like the time had come, or maybe because she needed air, Krystal pulled away long enough so speak.

"In case you couldn't tell, that was a yes."

"I was hoping, but I didn't want to make any assumptions." She grinned at my stupid joke and kissed me again, though this time, it was far more tender, which I enjoyed as well. When it ended, I continued. "Also, a fair warning: the others are putting together a party for us back at Charlotte Manor. I figured that if you said yes, we'd want to celebrate, and if you said no, then I'd want my friends and some cake."

"Bubba found out and insisted on throwing a shindig, didn't he?" Krystal asked.

"Very much so," I admitted. "But I didn't object as much you'd expect, so I'm counting that as partial credit for planning it."

"That seems fair."

Krystal got to her feet, and I followed her lead, pausing to lift the ring from its box. Carefully, my hands still a bit shaky, I slid the metal circle topped with a diamond onto her finger. It went on without issue, gleaming in the night's gentle light. She stared at it, tilting it to and fro as she admired her new accessory. "It's beautiful. You picked a good one."

"We both did." That earned me a laugh—the short kind that burst from her mouth when she was genuinely caught off guard. Those were my favorite.

"I should probably give you a little warning, though. Us getting hitched will come with some . . . unique paperwork issues," Krystal told me.



“But we can deal with those later. Tonight, let’s celebrate.”

While not generally one to put off paperwork, on this occasion, I was in full agreement. There would be time to deal with the inevitable hurdles and obstacles of such a union, but it wouldn’t be this evening. Tonight was about friends, and cheer, and the overwhelming joy of finding someone to share our lives with. The rest could wait until we were damn well ready for it.

My fiancé took my arm once more, and we began walking back the way we’d come. It was time to go home.

## About the Author



Drew Hayes is an aspiring author from Texas who has written several books and found the gumption to publish a few (so far). He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.

## Connect with Drew

Thank you for reading my book. If you enjoyed it, won't you please take a moment to

leave me a review at your favorite retailer? Or, connect with me below!

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A hand is shown typing on a silver laptop keyboard. The laptop screen displays a document with a table and a pie chart. A yellow notepad with the name 'Drew Hayes' and bloodstains is on the desk. Two black banners with white text are overlaid on the keyboard.

# BLOODY ACQUISITIONS

Drew Hayes

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# Dedication

*This book, the third in a series I wasn't sure would get off the ground beyond the first, goes out to the wonderful readers who've made this possible. Thank you for taking a chance on the strange tales of a socially awkward vampire accountant, whose stories I hope to be telling for a long time to come.*

## Preface

I almost certainly do not know you; however, I shall assume you are a lovely person, and it is my loss for not having yet had the opportunity to meet you. Still, I must assume you and I are connected in some way, for the works you are about to read are selections from a journal of my memoirs. I compiled these not in the belief that the stories within are so compelling they must be told, but rather because I found my unexpected life transition to be so shockingly uneventful—at least initially. I place the blame for my aggrandized expectations squarely on contemporary media, filling my head with the belief that a ticket to the supernatural also put one on an express train toward coolness and suave charm.

This is simply not the case. Or, at least, it was not my case. I recorded my journeys in the hopes that, should another being find themselves utterly depressed at the humdrum personality still saddling their supernatural frame, they might find solace in knowing they are not the only one to have felt that way. Given the lengthy lifespan of many of the people with whom I associate, there is no guarantee they will have passed on by the time this is read. Therefore, names have been changed as I deemed necessary.

So, dear reader, whom I suspect is a wonderful person merely in need of a bit of reassurance, take comfort in my tales of uneventful blundering. One's nature is hard to change; sometimes even death is insufficient to accomplish such a task. But be assured that, while you might find yourself still more human than anticipated, you are far from the only one. You will eventually discover that under the movie stereotypes, imposed mystique, and overall inflated expectations, each and every one of us is at least a touch more boring than our images would indicate.

And that is not a bad thing.

—Fredrick Frankford Fletcher

# A Hunter in the Streets

## 1.

“While I’m glad you don’t fall into the old female stereotype of having lots of shoes, part of me wishes you did. I’d much prefer to be lugging around high heels than yet another box full of guns.” As gently as I possibly could, I set the cardboard cube down on Krystal’s empty counter. Normally, there was nowhere near enough kitchen space cleaned off to fit even a single glass, let alone a whole box of armaments, but today was different. Today, her entire apartment was almost stripped bare, with much of the furniture going off into storage or being returned to the rental locations they’d been taken from.

Today was moving day, which was why I’d been roped into helping to haul the possessions she was keeping—including what had to be an illegal amount of firearms even for an agent—off to her new home.

“Don’t be such a baby. My collection is nothing. You should see the armory that Arch carts around everywhere.” Krystal emerged from her bedroom, a duffel bag packed with more of her knives, batons, and other melee gear rattling on her shoulder. “Plus, like I’ve been saying ever since the word came down, this is ultimately all your fault. Once the Agency found out what a deal you’d gotten for Arch, they didn’t see the sense in paying for me to have a more expensive, less defended apartment.”

While “fault” seemed like an aggressive term, there was no denying that I had set in motion the chain of events which resulted in Krystal’s fellow agent, Arch, moving into the animated house on the outskirts of Winslow, Colorado known as Charlotte Manor. On top of coming with three meals a day and all utilities included, Charlotte was also something of a magical fortress, built by a commune of insane mages and meant to repel all but the most powerful of attackers. Granted, not everyone would be thrilled by the idea of living in a

home that was self-aware and always watching, but for people like Krystal and Arch, the loss of privacy was well worth it to be able to sleep with both eyes shut.

But perhaps I should step back briefly, in case those last few lines seem like the raving of a madman or incomprehensible gibberish. My name is Fredrick Frankford Fletcher, and I am a Certified Public Parahuman Accountant. Also, a vampire. Despite what film and television might have led to you believe, joining the undead does not inherently make one suave, cool, or even particularly more socially competent. What it does do, however, is thrust you into a community that lives in the normal world's shadow, a society comprised of parahumans. That very community has technically endangered my undead life several times, but it has also helped me meet a variety of friends I would never have run across in my mortal days, so it's not that bad of a trade. Krystal, my girlfriend, makes her living working for the agency that polices our kind, ensuring that all the laws and treaties of our various peoples are upheld. It keeps her on the road a lot, which is just one more reason why moving to Charlotte Manor made more sense than her previous arrangement.

We hauled our respective loads down the stairs, setting them into the back cab of Krystal's pickup truck, where she'd saved a space specifically for the weaponry. My hybrid was already filled with the more mundane objects like clothing and dishes, rather than firearms and blades. She had the security clearance to be walking around with half a riot squad's arsenal; I didn't, and even for vampires, traffic stops are still a possibility.

"And that . . . is it." Krystal slammed the door closed, causing me to jump as I waited to hear the guns go off, despite her assurances that they were all unloaded. She chuckled, but didn't call me out on being startled, likely because I was in the middle of doing her a favor. "Bubba and Amy should be about done with their load by now, so once we get the dangerous stuff inside, we can break for night-lunch."

Much as I wished she'd think of a new term for our customary meal around midnight, being my equivalent of a mid-day point, I was never going to object to enjoying Charlotte's cooking. While it's true that I primarily need blood to survive, I can still dine on human food. My body gains no nutrients from it, but that's never really the best part of eating a fine meal anyway, is it?

"I just have to swing by my place real quick to fire off an email," I told her. "Promised to have some acquisition forms sent out before morning."

"Can't Albert do that?" Krystal asked.

"You already dragged Albert and Neil into helping you move," I reminded her. "They took the first couple of boxes. And anyway, there's a bit of prep work to do, which puts it out of Albert's depth. Great assistant or not, some tasks require my personal touch."

Krystal leered at me for a few seconds—her way of letting me know I was on thin ice—before finally relenting with a sigh. “I’ll let it slide this time, but don’t take too long. These boxes aren’t going to unpack themselves.”

“I promise to be as quick as possible,” I assured her.

“I’d prefer you promise to hire some more help,” Krystal shot back. “Even vampires need rest, you know.”

She had me there. When I first got my CPPA license and began courting parahuman clients, I’d been fearful there wouldn’t be enough business to sustain the investment. What I discovered was that this was a hole in the market that desperately required filling, and over the past few months, it had been all I could do to keep up with the influx of new clients. Fletcher Accounting Services needed to expand, which was far easier said than done. Parahumans might be in ample supply, but precious few of them wanted to make their living as accountants.

“It would be nice,” I agreed. “My original plan was to get Albert trained up as he grew more familiar with the practice, and then pay for him to obtain the necessary accounting degrees. But with the sword training, that’s just not viable.” Several months prior, Albert had pulled the Blade of the Unlikely Champion from its sheath. Technically, that didn’t come with any built-in responsibilities; however, everyone had agreed it was best he get comfortable using it, just in case. Which, in fact, was why Arch had moved to Winslow and needed somewhere to stay in the first place. Despite seeming human, Arch was quite old, and renowned for his abilities as a trainer, among other things.

“I’ll keep an ear to the ground, just in case I come across any good candidates.” Krystal pulled open the door to her truck, then paused to lean in and give me a short, but forceful, kiss. “Don’t take too long with your work, or I’ll let them start night-lunch without you.”

“Only a few minutes, at most.” She let it be, getting into her truck and heading off before I’d so much as gotten my own car’s door unlocked.

The truth of the matter was that I knew exactly how long the work would take, and it would be seconds, at most. I’d purposely left it undone specifically so I’d have an excuse to split up from her when the last load was packed. I’m not a terrible liar, but Krystal is an agent for a reason, and telling the truth made it far less likely that the real reason I was going back to my apartment would be uncovered.

After all, it wouldn’t be much of a surprise housewarming party without the surprise part. Or a cake, specially ordered from a bakery back in Krystal’s and my hometown of Kent. It was a favorite of both of ours, and a nice way to ring in the new with the old. But I needed to hurry. The plan was for everyone to distract her with unpacking while I picked up the cake and brought it to Charlotte Manor.

Turning on my engine, I started to floor it, then remembered my car was full of Krystal's possessions—some of which were almost certain to be illegal for a non-agent to have, dishes or no—and resumed a far more moderate pace.

## 2.

It turned out to be a good thing that I was driving so carefully, because, if I'd come racing up to my building, the spiky metal balls hurled under my tires might have caused me to completely spin out of control. As it was, I held on to the wheel as three of my four tires blew out at once, foot pressing on the brake so hard that I worried I'd snap it off, until I came skidding to a merciful stop a few feet from the curb. Thankfully, the late hour and lack of nightlife in my neighborhood meant the streets were clear, so I didn't hurt anyone as I scrambled to get my automobile halted. That didn't last long, though. I'd barely begun to reach for the door, my fingers shaking from shock and fear, when a new figure stepped out from a nearby alley.

He was tall, with close-cut brown hair and a scar just below his left eye. A large brown coat concealed most of his body, but when he moved, I could catch a peek inside, which was not a comforting sight. Wooden stakes, bulbs of garlic, the telltale shine of guns, silver chains, and several other bulges I couldn't quite make out during my brief glimpse all sent my usually anxious mind into overdrive. His hands dipped inside, coming out with a pair of pistols. Krystal could have told me the make and model, but all I knew was that they were big, and would undoubtedly punch a bloody hole in any part of me they were aimed at.

I froze, fingers still wrapped around the handle, until he motioned for me to get out of the car. With only one good tire, escape was off the table, so I didn't have a lot of choice. Besides, I was sure this was some sort of misunderstanding. Maybe an agent had been given the wrong address for a rogue vampire, one who didn't adhere to the law as carefully as me. A simple call would sort it right out. At least, that's what I told myself as I climbed slowly out of my car.

"Don't move. Don't try anything." He barked more than spoke, gesturing



with the guns. Now that I was out, I could catch a glimpse of his eyes for the first time, and I noticed how wild they seemed. Every agent I'd met was a bastion of control—even Krystal's chaotic attitude came with a carefully measured understanding of how much force was needed. But this man . . . I felt like he could begin firing at any moment. That certainty I'd had about the misunderstanding began to erode, ever so slightly.

"Empty your pockets on the ground." It struck me that I might just be getting mugged, which was an oddly comforting thought. Possessions could be replaced, and some crook was far less dangerous than a person actually keyed in to the parahuman world.

I did as I was told, dropping my wallet, car keys, and cell phone to the concrete. As soon as the last item hit the ground, he took quick aim and fired, causing me to jump back and turning my phone into nothing more than plastic debris. Undead or not, guns are scary things, especially when pointed at you, and I decided it was time to try and start extricating myself from this situation.

"I'm not sure what charges are being leveled at me, but I'm willing to go along peacefully," I told him. "If you could reach out to Agent Jenkins, I'll trust her to arrange proper representation. We do still get lawyers, right?" It had never occurred to me until this very moment, yet it suddenly seemed strikingly relevant. America's constitution did provide representation for all its citizens, but parahumans had a somewhat different set of rules. Since they helped form the country, they'd negotiated their own sets of laws to accommodate the need for things like hunting and magic. Sometimes it meant we could get away with more than normal humans, sometimes less. I imagined due process had to be factored in there somewhere, though.

"Representation?" He sneered at me, those wild eyes twitching irregularly. "You think I'm dumb enough to take you to the cops? I know what you are, and I know those cells couldn't hold you for long. Isn't that right, *vampire*?"

The way he said it, like it was a big reveal . . . I think I was supposed to react more. Like the silver chains and garlic didn't give away what he thought he was confronting. Although, now that I finally had a chance to think about it, why would an agent bring garlic? Vampires are allergic to it, but only in the sense that our lips get puffy and our throats sore. It's useless in any real capacity, and an agent would definitely know that.

"You're not affiliated with the Agency, are you?"

"Keep talking nonsense, and I'll do this right here in the street," he snapped. "No, I'm not part of whatever organization you use. Just a man who saw what was happening and couldn't stand for it any longer. Took me a long while to find this town's first vampire, until I thought to stake out the local hospital's blood supply. Your little flunky didn't want to talk, loyal one you've got there, but I got it out of him eventually."

“You didn’t . . . ?” Granted, what Dr. Huerta and I had was purely a business relationship—he sold me blood and I, in turn, worked the hospital’s books to keep them afloat come tax season—but I certainly didn’t want the man dead.

“No, I don’t kill humans. Just monsters.” Slowly lowering one of the guns, the other staying tight on my center of mass, he pulled out a length of silver chain from under his coat and tossed it onto the sidewalk in front of me.

“Wrap yourself.”

“And if I do, then what?” It wasn’t that I was suddenly feeling brave; it was more like the rational part of my brain was finally beginning to outpace my fearful reaction to the sudden surprise. Whoever this man was, he obviously wasn’t an agent. While that made him weaker, physically, it also made him more dangerous. Agents were part of something with rules; they were accountable. That seemed unlikely with my would-be kidnapper, which meant going along peacefully could be more dangerous than making a break for it. Well-prepared or not, there was no way he could keep up with the strength in my undead legs and lungs that didn’t need air.

“Then we go for a drive, and when we get somewhere more private, you’re telling me everything you know about all the other bloodsuckers in this area. If you do that, then I’ll make it quick. If not . . . well, I’ve got nowhere to be, and you monsters seem to be able to take a lot of punishment.”

If I’d had any lingering doubts about the value of running away versus trying to reason this out with him, those words killed them. This man was unhinged, and while someone obviously needed to deal with him, that . . . well, that was what agents were for. My best bet was to escape, contact Krystal, and let her know there was a madman who fancied himself a vampire hunter on the loose.

He was staring at me, and the longer I waited to touch the chains, the tighter his grip on the trigger grew. Getting out of here without any bloodshed seemed more or less impossible, but I could at least keep it minimized. Leaning forward, I started to reach for the chains. When I was a few inches away, I saw him relax just a bit. Little as it was, I still seized the opportunity, lunging to the side with balance precious few humans could hope to match and launching into a dead sprint down the sidewalk.

I felt the bullet hit at the same time I heard the gunshot, tearing through the back of my shoulder and wedging itself somewhere around my spine. If not for the natural toughness of my vampiric body, it likely would have carved straight through me. As it was, the bullet stung, and the shock of the impact caused me to stumble slightly.

“How’s that feel, monster? The silver burning you as it rips apart your flesh? I’m still learning about what works on you things, but I’ve seen firsthand just how potent silver is at putting you down.” He was walking

toward me, no doubt expecting me to fall to the ground in a heap as the bullet did its work.

Truthfully, it was a pretty good stopping measure, as such things went. Silver acts a magical insulator and disruptor, weakening most parahumans just by touching them. Shoot us with a silver bullet, and the most we'll manage is a crawl. However, the problem with that strategy was that it only works on *most* parahumans. Some come from other realms and have reactions to different metals, like the Fey and their aversion to iron. Others, such as dragons, are either immune or so powerful that their magic can't be insulated—no one is entirely sure.

As for me, several months prior I'd allowed an ancient dragon of immeasurable power to use my body as a conduit to escape his prison. The process hadn't been a fun one, and I'd needed a lot of blood and rest when it was over, but overall, I'd come out more or less unscathed. Except for the one odd side effect that no one had been able to entirely explain: I was no longer bothered by silver.

For some vampires, that might have been a boon that made them incredible warriors, nigh unstoppable on the battlefield. I, however, used that immunity to recover from my stumble and kept on running away from the crazy man in the coat.

"Hey!" He let out a yelp of surprise as I dashed into the night, firing off a few more rounds. I felt one of them graze my back but not actually break the skin, and assumed he'd traded out for regular bullets.

Within seconds, I turned the corner, and after another minute of running, not even my enhanced ears could hear his chasing footsteps anymore.

### 3.

After a few minutes of racing through town, it began to occur to me that I had no real idea of where I was going. In the initial burst of panic, my plan had been simply to get away as fast as possible. Now that I was out of immediate danger, it was time to move on to step two, which I had in no way tried to come up with.

I slowed my run, taking in my surroundings. Winslow was a large city, not quite metropolitan but far from the farming town I'd grown up in. This area wasn't familiar, which was hardly surprising given that I'm an introvert who usually works from home, but there were well-lit street signs I could use to get my bearings. The comfort of that thought lasted exactly as long as it took me to dip my hand into my empty pocket and realize my phone was in pieces on a sidewalk. Inconvenient as that was already, it was made doubly worse by the fact that I, like most people in the modern age, also used the GPS function to guide me around. Without my phone, I had no idea how to get anywhere familiar.

Taking deep breathes to try and relax—some habits refused to die even though I already had—I fought down a rising wave of panic and forced myself to think. Paper maps still existed, not that I had the money to buy one, but if I found a gas station, I might be able to figure out where I was and a route to take me somewhere safe. Or, if they happened to have a phone book, there was a chance I could look up the number to Charlotte Manor and let everyone know I needed a lift. Granted, if I remembered their numbers, I could just call direct with any phone, but of course, I hadn't needed to dial them since putting the numbers in my phone the first time. I cursed myself for becoming so dependent on modern conveniences, even as I began to jog down the street looking for any open businesses.

With nothing else to do but think and search, my natural instinct to worry

soon kicked in. The concern at the top of the heap was for Dr. Huerta, who it seemed was alive, but likely in rough shape. Given how quickly the vampire hunter had gone to the torture method with me, it seemed a good guess he wasn't shy about using pain to get information, even from humans. Once this was all over, I'd make a point to check in on Dr. Huerta, mostly to see if he was all right. In my truest heart, I knew there would be a selfish component to the visit as well. Being tortured by an insane man because he was stealing blood would quite likely put a strain on our working relationship. There was a very real possibility that, after tonight, I'd have to find a new source of blood, which would be far more problematic than just dealing with a crazy man.

Luckily, I didn't get too far into a building anxiety spiral before my eyes fell upon the familiar blue glow of a Slurp Stop gas station sign. It was a bit run down, but the lights were on and I could see a clerk standing at the counter, visibly bored as he tapped away at his phone's screen. I hurried across the street, stepping into the station and causing the small bell overhead to let out a shrill jingle.

The clerk glanced up from his phone. "Welcome to Slurp Stop, how can I—holy shit!" His eyes went wide and the phone fell from his hand, clattering to the floor. "Hang on, dude, I'll call an ambulance."

For a moment, I just stared at him, genuinely puzzled. What on earth was he talking about? Then it hit me: his vantage point let him see me from the side, which meant he was at least catching a glimpse of the blood-stained tears in the back of my shirt and sweater vest. The wounds had already closed—we vampires are known for our rapid healing—but the evidence of the shooting still remained. Add in that I have the tell-tale pale pallor of a vampire, and it probably looked like I'd been shot and was on the verge of bleeding out.

"Oh, oh no, no, no." I held up my hands, though I have no idea why. It just seemed like the right motion to try and reassure him. "I'm fine. Well, not *fine* fine, I do need to use your phone if it's okay, but this is . . . for a costume party." We were nowhere near Halloween, so I'm not certain what on earth made me feel like this was an acceptable excuse for wearing a torn and bloody shirt. Strangely enough, though, it worked, and he began to nod, looking less like he was on the verge of fainting.

"Are you going as a shooting victim?" Now that the emergency had passed, he sounded more annoyed than bothered. Guess he didn't enjoy being made to think that someone on death's door had just stumbled in during his shift.

"Sure. It was what I could throw together at the last minute." The rest of the tension finally left his body; evidently, that was a sentiment he could comprehend. A small bell, different from the one over the door, drew his eyes away from mine as a pair of headlights flashed through the window. A beat-

up sedan was pulling into the nearest pump, no doubt refueling for its own late-night adventures.

“Hang on.” The clerk reached under the counter and hefted up a phone book that was at least three years old, a fact which would have been more concerning if Charlotte Manor hadn’t been a Bed and Breakfast for several decades. He spun a large phone with a curly cord over from behind the register and pushed it to the edge of the counter. “I think I’m supposed to make you buy something before you can use this.”

“That would be problematic,” I admitted. “I was . . . let’s say mugged, a few minutes ago. It’s why I don’t have my own phone in the first place.”

“Sort of figured.” The clerk sighed, then nodded to the phone and the book. “It’s cool, man. No one really cares about what happens on the night shift.”

“Thank you so much.” I rushed forward, picking up the massive tome of thin pages and flipping through them. The sooner I found Charlotte’s number, the sooner I could alert the others, and the sooner Krystal could get the proper authorities after that psycho. I was only inconvenienced by bullet wounds, but the next person he went after, parahuman or not, might not be so lucky.

This time, the bell I heard was the one for the door, though I didn’t find that particularly odd. Someone buying gas would have to pay for it, obviously. The sound of what movies had told me was a shotgun being pumped did prick my attention, however. Even then, I might have been able to convince myself it was just a robbery, if not for the scream of “Die, you monster!” that came just before the gunshot.

I didn’t bother glancing behind me; instead, I hurled myself over the counter, tackling the clerk to the ground in the process. Quick I was, I still felt some of the shotgun’s blast on my leg as we fell, but the more vulnerable flesh of the clerk remained mercifully unmarred.

“Shit! I’ll give you the money. You just had to ask!” Fundamentally misunderstanding what was happening (and really, who could blame him?), the clerk was yelling from our prone position even as he worked to get out from under me.

I took the opportunity to glance at one of the many anti-shoplifting mirrors that provided a comprehensive view of the store from the counter. Sure enough, it was my hunter, looking even more angry and deranged than when I’d given him the slip. He pumped the shotgun again, sending a spent casing tumbling to the ground, and I had to wonder how much he knew about forensic science. Leaving evidence all over like that, he’d soon have the regular police on him as well. And given that he’d just shown a willingness to bring down bystanders, that didn’t bode well for those who came to collect him.

“I thought you didn’t kill humans!” At this point, my mind was racing,

trying to figure out how he'd located me and, more importantly, how to get away. At least if I could make him talk, I might buy a few seconds to work things out.

"I don't. Not intentionally." He wasn't yelling his replies, just stating them like cold facts, which only served to make me more worried. "But every war has casualties. Better one lost now than all the others you'd kill."

And now the clerk was staring at me, and my bloody shirt, in a whole new light. Hopefully, he'd write this all off as the insane screams of two mentally ill people who'd wandered into his gas station. That was the best case scenario for him, at least.

"You keep saying things like that, but I don't hurt anyone. I'm just an accountant!"

"I know what your kind does. I've seen it. Save your lies for the Devil, monster." Now I could hear the emotion in his voice—fury and loss twisted together like coiled serpents around his heart. That was when I knew, for sure and for certain, that no amount of talk would get through to him. Not from me, anyway. I needed to get him out of here and away from the clerk, lest he decide to torture someone for the sin of helping me.

"When I get up, you need to sneak out of here," I whispered to the clerk. "I'll buy you time, but you have to *go*. Understand?"

There must have been someone in the heavens looking out for me, because the clerk nodded his head and then flipped his position around, ready to move.

Moving slowly, because not even I was sure I could survive a shotgun blast to the head, I emerged from behind the counter with my hands held up. With one large step, I moved on top of the counter, then slid down the front, ending up with only a few feet between me and the hunter. He watched me with those same wild eyes, never letting a single one of my motions escape his gaze. That was exactly what I wanted, though, as it meant he wasn't watching as the clerk crawled along the floor, keeping below displays and making his way toward the back of the gas station.

"What's your name?" I'll be honest, even I'm not sure what I was hoping to accomplish, I just wanted to create noise in order to muffle the clerk's escape attempt. My ears were primed, tracking his every movement until he was safe, which would be my cue to run for it. That said, I wanted to be the only one aware of that movement, which is why I started up the small talk again.

"Trying to befriend me now? To weave a new set of lies?" His finger grew tighter on the trigger.

"Every man deserves to know the name of their executioner," I said, though, looking back, I'm almost certain I stole the line from an old noir film. Like I mentioned earlier, I was very much just running on whatever popped

into mind.

“Maybe so, but you’re not a man, you’re—”

“A monster? You know, we don’t really like that word. Lot of connotation that purposely paints us in a negative light. Some consider it a very pointed insult.”

“I’ll be sure to keep that in mind. When I kill the next one.” He took a step closer to me, keeping the gun steady. “My name is Colin. If there’s an afterlife for you things, be sure to tell the others I sent you there.”

“Nice to meet you, Colin. I’m Fred.” Here, a mix of fear, worry, and habit convalesced into my defaulting to professionalism. I could hear the clerk getting to his feet from across the station; it was almost time to act.

“A real pleasure, Fred.” He began to lift the gun, no doubt lining up a shot with my skull. “Time for you to die.”

And just like that, everything suddenly went black.



## 4.

It took a moment for me to realize that my life hadn't ended for the second time, and that my head was still rightly attached to my shoulders. The clerk, that wondrous little slacker, hadn't just run out the back, he'd also killed the power on his way, plunging the entire gas station into darkness. For the hunter, that was a serious issue, but vampires are made to be nocturnal. If anything, our vision in darkness is better than in light. I seized on the moment of confusion and darted to the side, out of the area where he'd been preparing to open fire.

The report of the shotgun blast made it clear that I hadn't moved a moment too soon, as the hunter heard me racing through the station and realized his moment of hesitation had cost him the opportunity. Another shot, this one wild, obliterated a display of beef jerky twenty feet to my left. He was aiming blind, but eventually his eyes would adjust and I'd be in trouble again. Best to go while the going was good.

I burst through the front door, hitting it so hard I shattered the glass and knocked the metal frame out of the wall. Another shot and the sound of more breaking glass told me that he'd been able to follow at least the basics of my movement. I was about to start racing down the street again when my eyes fell upon the beat-up sedan that had pulled into the gas station. While I didn't know how he'd managed to find me, this was obviously how he'd been able to match my vampiric running speed. If I could disable his ride, I might be able to shake him for good.

It would have been a simple matter half a year earlier, when a drop of dragon's blood was augmenting my strength to incredible levels. Then, I likely could have flipped the whole thing over, or put a fist through the engine. Vampire strength on its own wasn't quite up to that level, however, so I was forced to take a far more unpleasant option.

Darting to the side, I raced up to one of his tires, opened wide, and sank my fangs into the rubber. While I usually considered keeping my sense of taste a true blessing, at that moment I'd have traded all the fine cooking and wine in the world to have a dead palette. I'd bitten into fire extinguishers that were less disgusting than the mouth full of tire I had to chew on. If I were able to throw up, I doubtlessly would have, but since vampires lack that reaction, I instead pulled back, ripping out a massive chunk of tire and then spitting it to the ground. Awful as it had been, my goal was accomplished; there was no way he was going anywhere until he got a new tire, and by then I'd be long gone.

The sound of footsteps on broken glass alerted me that he'd left the station, so I didn't waste any more time. Keeping clear of the pumps, because he definitely seemed like someone crazy enough to shoot at gasoline containers, I began another sprint, running as hard and as fast as I could away from Colin the hunter. I kept up the pace for a solid ten minutes, ignoring the strange stares of the few people out and about as I whipped by them at inhuman speeds. While I usually preferred discretion at all costs, it was definitely taking a back seat to survival.

Finally, I slowed down and tried to get my bearings. This section of Winslow at least looked a little familiar, and I realized that I'd run to a part of town not far off from Richard Alderson's office. Ordinarily, that would have been as good as salvation, since the local head of the therianthropes (the general term for all were-creatures) was a client and a friend who certainly would have offered me shelter. Unfortunately, he, along with his young daughter Sally, were also guests at Krystal's surprise party, which by now had likely kicked off, cake or no. I could try and approach the office anyway, but most therians had a bit of suspicion as far as vampires were concerned. My kind had a bad history of feeding off therians to increase our own power, so I was tolerated only due to my usefulness to Richard.

Of course, there was always the possibility that Gideon, the King of the West, was still in the office. I was never really sure where I stood with him, though. The ancient dragon who masqueraded as a child didn't appear to loathe me, but I wasn't certain he'd intervene on my behalf, either. And if I strolled up to the front doors with a madman on my tail, that could put the other therians in danger. There was no way they were going to look kindly on that kind of stunt. But I might be able to talk someone into letting me use a phone, which was still my best bet at salvation.

Eventually, I decided to start heading in that direction, keeping my eyes open for better options. I didn't want to endanger another innocent person, but I still had no idea how to get to Charlotte Manor outside of using the highways, and someone racing down the road in that public of a spot was bound to be noticed. Scary as Colin the crazed hunter was, I still preferred

him to Krystal's Agency being pissed that I put parahumans in the public eye. They were not well known for their kind or forgiving nature.

As the sound of my loafers echoed through the empty street, I fell into something of a pensive state, my mind no doubt trying to find some solid ground after braving the tidal wave of crazy that was my night so far. I imagined how nice it would be to finally make it back to Charlotte Manor, where everything in the world I cared about currently was. It was strange to think that all of my friends and loved ones were gathered together right now, safe and happy and nowhere near the danger that was bloodying my clothes piece by piece. The oddness was not that I begrudged their being out of harm's way—it was a far cry better than seeing them in peril—but because it was usually those friends who got me into trouble in the first place. Tonight, however, was completely my own doing. My arrangement with a hospital had been the clue Colin used to find me. If I'd never gone to my high school reunion, never met Krystal and by extension everyone else, this still would have been happening. And part of me wondered, without those friends constantly exposing me to some measure of adventure, how would the old Fred have handled things?

Truth be told, I didn't think he would have survived that first encounter. Even if they weren't actually here at the moment, the experiences my odd little family had given me were what kept me alive. It made me long to be back with them all the more, and I finally noticed that I'd unconsciously quickened my step. I was hurrying toward Richard's building, carried by feet that were too ready to be done with the evening to fear being turned away at the door.

With no other real options, I decided that perhaps it was best just to roll the dice. I needed help, there was no shame in admitting that, and without his car, the odds of Colin tracking me were negligible. Even if he did somehow know where I went, at most he'd have cause to think I went to a big building full of offices, and one garish club, to try and use their phone. At least, that was the thought process I hoped he'd have.

I could see Richard's building when I was suddenly spotlighted in the headlights of a car pulling out from the road in front of me. My body tensed, ready for Colin to point a gun out the window or try to run me down, but then I noticed the bright yellow color of the vehicle and realized it was just a cab, probably taking someone home from a late night at the bar.

Unfortunately, my tense body turned out to be smarter than my logical brain as the tires beneath the cab began to spin and it lurched forward, trying to turn me into nothing more than a smear on the road. As it raced toward me, I caught a glimpse of the man behind the wheel.

Sure enough, there were the mad eyes of Colin as he floored the accelerator, trying with all he had to run me over.



## 5.

While in life my reaction speed was always somewhere between “abysmal” and “for the love of heaven don’t let Fred hold anything too valuable,” the turn to undead had sharpened my reflexes significantly. Granted, they were nowhere near as potent as they would have been if I were even remotely physically gifted when alive, but sometimes all you need is good enough. In this case, good enough was allowing me to leap out of the way of an oncoming taxi cab as it careened toward me, only dodging the bumper’s left corner by a few inches.

The screech of tires filled the air as Colin jerked the wheel around, trying to get another run at me, but now that the element of surprise was gone, he had no hope of outmaneuvering me. I began to race up the street again, when a sound unlike any gun I’d ever heard filled the air. Pain, dull and muted but still present, filled me as I looked over at my previously unshot shoulder. Now, the tip of a large metal claw was sticking out, smaller tines already dug into my flesh. Unbidden memories of watching nature documentaries filled my head as I recognized the iconic shape.

“Did you just harpoon me?”

“Modified it a little to cling on to you slippery bastards.” Colin was leaning out the window, spear gun in hand, and that was when I saw the length of metal cord running from the back of my shoulder to the butt of the gun. Not wasting any time, Colin jerked it in, bracing the gun against something unseen inside, and threw the taxi into reverse.

While I might have physically been able to react in time, I was mentally still processing the fact that someone had *harpooned* me in the middle of the street, which was why I didn’t understand what Colin was doing until the cord pulled taut and my feet went out from under me. I bounced off the road once, then twice, then finally got my feet under me and ran along rather than be

dragged. Had Colin floored it again, not even I would have been able to keep pace, but he seemed content to keep the speed manageable. He was leading me, trying to get me to a place without as much room to run.

I tried to pull out the harpoon, but every time I reached for it Colin accelerated, knocking me off balance if not outright sending me sprawling. It still might have been manageable, even with the shifting speeds; however, my own regeneration was working against me. The wound around the spear had almost completely sealed up, meaning that instead of just pulling it back out through the same area, I had to try and rip apart my own resilient vampire flesh.

Much as I disliked Colin, I couldn't say he hadn't come up with an effective method for ensnaring vampires.

We didn't travel far, only a few blocks down the road. Colin backed the cab into an alley behind a closed noodle shop I'd loved to order from before they went out of business, and killed the engine. He stepped out from the cab, dark coat still flapping, showing off the wide array of weapons he had tucked about inside. The spear gun wasn't one of those, as he left it wedged in the cab even as he stepped away. I was still on a line, and unless I found a way to yank the harpoon out or drag an entire cab along with me, he'd finally managed to take running away off the table.

"You are a tricky one," Colin noted, pulling out his pistol again. "Silver has stopped every vampire I've dealt with, so why didn't it work on you?"

"Kind of a long story, and honestly, I doubt you'd believe me." My hands fumbled with the harpoon, tugging at it as I tried to get free. The hooks were made to keep me from pulling it back out, which meant forward was the only option. Of course, then I'd still have a metal rope running through me, and I wasn't sure my hands alone could snap something like that. There was the option of biting through it—I'd met very little a vampire's fangs couldn't pierce—but that was a lot of steps to freedom, and Colin wasn't going to wait patiently while I did them all.

"You're right, there; I'd never believe one of your lies." He reached into his coat with his free hand and pulled out a small squirt bottle, like the kind that go on bikes for long rides. "I've hunted a couple of your kind already, but you are far and away the worst of the lot. At least the others had the decency to own what they are. You, you burrowed into society like a tick, pretending to be normal, to be human. You tried to infiltrate us, and that makes you much too dangerous to live, even long enough to interrogate."

"There is another, far more logical explanation," I pointed out. "I lived in an apartment because it's my home, I bought my blood because I didn't want to hurt people, I kept working a normal job because I love what I do. This is just me. I'm not a monster, just a guy whose life took an unexpected turn."

"Whoever you might have been is dead. I know what lives inside you

creatures, and there's no goodness there. Just death and blood." He popped the top off the bottle and took a sniff, his nose recoiling slightly.

"Funny, by my count, you're the one who shot at an unarmed clerk, tortured a doctor, and, I'm assuming, stole a cabbie's car at gunpoint." My hand rested on the top of the harpoon. Maybe I didn't need to bother with the rope; if I just popped the hooked part off, I could yank the rest out and get free. That was still no easy task, but it seemed more viable than biting through the metal rope. And, more importantly, it seemed faster, which was starting to feel like a very important element in this encounter.

"Sometimes, you have to be a monster to kill a monster." Colin stepped forward, gun at the ready, and squirted me with the contents of the bottle. Even if I didn't have an incredible sense of smell, I'd have recognized the scent immediately: gasoline. He squeezed the bottle until it only spit out droplets and empty wheezes, then dropped the plastic container to the ground.

"Have you ever noticed that not once, despite everything you've done tonight, have I attacked or even tried to make a threatening move toward you?" Panic was slipping back into my voice, and with good reason, because while I might be immune to silver, there was no reason I would have any such resistance to fire. I knew for a fact that vampires could burn to death; it was the one death I'd witnessed up close and personally. Though, at the time, Krystal had been the one doing the burning, and the vampire in question was not one I'd miss.

"You sell the lie well, but I'm not going to be fooled." Colin reached back into his coat and pulled out a silver lighter, the old-fashioned kind without safety measures to keep it from burning without a thumb on the plunger. Behind him, I noticed a shadow move beyond the taxi. It was difficult even for my eyes to see, though, and I wasn't sure it had even been real.

"Colin, please listen to me, you're making a big mistake. I get that you hate vampires, I really do, and I don't know what you've had to do to survive before this, but what you're doing right now is murder. Beyond that, it's stepping into a world you *really* don't want to be a part of. Please, go turn yourself into the cops, do your time for the car theft and the gas station shooting, and then go on to live a normal life."

"That's a unique way to plead for your life, I'll give you that," Colin replied. He flicked the lighter and a bright orange flame sputtered forth from the top. I took hold of the hook, feeling the sharp blades cut through my palms as I readied to try with all my might to snap it off. This move was a gamble, but it was the best one I could make. If I managed to get clear, there had to be a way to end this without anyone getting hurt. I just needed to think harder.

"You really don't get it," I told him. "It's not my life I'm pleading for. If you do this, there's no going back. And the people who'll be coming for you

don't share my tendency to shy away from violence."

"Why would I want to go back? Especially with such a bright, warm future ahead of me." Colin reared back to toss the lighter, and I pushed down with all my might on the top of the hook. It bent down at a sharp angle, but refused to break, and in that instant, I knew I was dead.

As it turned out, however, Colin was no more successful with his toss than I with my escape attempt, as a sharp, sudden blow struck him across the back of the head. He crumpled to the ground, the lighter falling through the air for only a second before a pale, well-manicured hand snatched it up and snapped it shut.

"Wow, that guy seemed like a real asshole." The voice of my savior was soft, with undercurrents of an accent that had long since been worn away by time. She had dark hair trimmed to just above her shoulders, sported a pantsuit that would have fit right in at any office in America, and was as pale as a sheet. If that weren't enough, she flashed a small grin, just large enough for me to see an extended incisor at the top of her mouth.

For the first time since my own maker had tried to kill me, I was in the presence of another vampire.



## 6.

A slight groan broke the silent tension between this new vampire and me as Colin shifted on the ground. He was still unconscious, and given the amount of blood coming from his head, it would be some time before he was fully recovered. Actually, unless he had some sort of parahuman ability I hadn't noticed, an attack like that would leave him with neck, if not brain, damage. It's hard to understand just how fragile humans are until you stop technically being one.

"Sorry about that. Let's finish this jackass all the way off." The woman leaned down, mouth opening wider as her fangs began to extend even further.

"Stop!" I darted forward, spraying gasoline from my flailing limbs as I hurried to put myself between my savior and the hunter who had tried to kill me.

"Oh, my apologies. That was rude of me." She stopped, still bent halfway toward his unconscious form, then began to rise once more. "You're the one he attacked and stabbed, of course you should get to have the privilege. Not to mention, it looks like you could use the blood."

She had me there; the hooked head of the harpoon was bent but still lodged in my chest, tethering me to the car. What's more, my efforts to rip it off had re-opened the wound, which was slowly oozing a darker blood than normal. I mentioned before that vampires heal exceptionally well, but as I'd begun to learn, all magic came with a cost. For us, it was blood. Just like a human burned calories for energy, we burned blood, and the more strenuous the activity, the more it consumed. After racing around town and healing several gunshot wounds, I was feeling more than a bit peckish. A few nips from Colin's neck and I'd be topped off, able to easily free myself and heal up.

"Neither of us is drinking from him." The words were a little more

forceful than I'd meant them to be, and the female vampire regarded me more carefully. I quickly tried to explain myself.

"I mean, we need to wait for the authorities. The agents. He's obviously suffering from trauma or mental illness, and much as I might like to return the favor for this harpoon in my shoulder, I think it's for the best all-around if we let due process handle this."

She chuckled a little, a slightly higher pitch than I was expecting from her speaking voice. "Mind if I ask your name?"

"It's Fredrick Fletcher. But most people call me Fred."

"Fredrick, a classic name. I rather like those. I am Lillian." Without warning, she dipped her head and did a small formal bow. From the way her eyes went wide and she quickly sprang back up, I had a feeling it was more out of habit than deference.

"Well, Fred," Lillian continued. "This is the due process. This man, this human, tried to kill you. Have you committed any crime against him or his kin?"

"I . . . I don't think so. Not that I'm at all aware of."

"That doesn't surprise me; I've heard tales of a lone hunter going after our ilk lately. It was on my to-do list, some ways after tonight's meeting with the therians. At any rate, he tried to take your life, and as an Undead American, that means his life is yours to end. No muss, no fuss, no need for any *agents*."

Lillian spat that last word out, which didn't come as much of a surprise. Since I'd come to the parahuman world as an outsider, and my first friend in it was an agent, I hadn't been given the indoctrination of fear that a lot of others had. Truthfully, at first, I hadn't understood why everyone was so afraid of someone like Krystal. Then I saw Quinn, my maker, try to kill her. That sole experience had taught me that, if anything, people weren't afraid enough of agents.

"So, Colin's life is mine to take, right?" I asked, making sure I understood the minutia of what was happening. That's the thing about living in a country partly founded by parahumans: we do have rules about how things go, and arbitrary as they often felt, I knew that they mattered. Because agents existed specifically to deal with those who broke those rules.

"Correct," Lillian assured me.

"Then I choose not to take it. I spare him. And since he never even saw you, let alone fired a shot, I don't see that you have any similar claim. If you kill him, it's murder."

Bathed in the glow from the taxi's headlights, swaddled in the sounds of its still barely running engine, Lillian and I stared at each other for a long while. If she made this violent, I was done for. Even if I was normally a match for other vampires, which I wasn't, an evening of getting the utter crap kicked out of me had left me battered and weary. Unless Lillian was somehow more

averse to violence than myself, a notion which Colin's bleeding head easily dispelled, she'd take me down in seconds. Hell, she was still holding the lighter, which meant she didn't even really need to get her hands dirty.

"You surprise me," Lillian said, speaking at last. "Not with your softness—you are far from the first doe someone has tried to turn into a wolf—but that you noticed that detail. I'm impressed. Most in your state wouldn't be capable of keeping such a calm head. Unfortunately for you, and this hunter, there is one flaw in your argument. I am a vampire, and he is a criminal. That much I heard him confess myself. By the law, that means he is fair game for me to feed upon, and while I'll certainly try not to kill him, accidents do happen. So tell me, how will you save the hunter this time, Fredrick?"

I'm not proud of how long it took, but that was when it finally dawned on me that Lillian didn't actually care if Colin died or not. Somewhere in the discussion, he'd become inconsequential. What she was interested in was me, or rather, if I could stop her from killing him. This was a game to her. Brains or brawn, she wanted to see what I was made of. Knowing that, I realized I only had one move left. I needed to go for a high stakes gambit.

"I guess I can't stop you," I told her, but even as I spoke, I began to back away. "Just, give me a few seconds to get clear first. I really don't want to be close enough to see what happens to you."

Her brow creased. This was not a method she'd been anticipating, because why on earth would she? It didn't really make sense, but if I shuffled the facts around fast enough, she might not notice that.

"What do you expect to happen? The hunter is down. I would easily sense if he'd awakened."

"Oh yeah, Colin looks down for the count. In fact, I think he needs some serious medical attention. But see, nuts as that hunter is, he's also shown himself to be really smart. He found out what I was by staking out my blood supply. He took away my car and communication before anything else. When I ran, he kept finding me, and I still have no idea how he pulled that off. Not to mention his weapons. Silver, fire, all the classics, plus some ingenious stuff of his own." I tapped lightly on the hook sticking out of my chest to illustrate the point.

"I'm sure he was quite formidable, before I cracked him in the back of the head," Lillian said. Her brow was still creased, but she was starting to grow impatient. She thought I was stalling for time, instead of building up to something.

"Formidable, and suicidal," I corrected. "No concern for his own well-being what-so-ever. If I weren't . . . me . . . then there were several chances I could have used to kill him tonight. Tell me, someone like that—someone cunning and informed, with very little sense of self-preservation—doesn't that seem like the kind of man who would booby trap his own blood, just in

case he lost? One last ‘screw you’ to the vampire that brought him down?”

That got her attention. She looked from me to Colin, to the blood slowly streaming from his forehead. “Silver is poisonous to humans as well.”

“Not right away. They can have a lot of it in their system before it does them in. There would be long-term side effects, but that only matters for someone who expects to live through the year. And it wouldn’t take much to hurt a vampire, especially from the inside.” It took everything I had not to fidget, or break our eye contact, or give any other indication of just how full of shit I was. I had no idea how long a human could last with silver in their body, or what amount of it would get to the blood, or how it would impact a vampire who drank it. This was all speculation and conjecture, which is a nicer way of saying a complete wild guess. It was all I had, though.

My only hope—actually, Colin’s only hope—was that Lillian didn’t know any more about the subject than I did. She contemplated him again for a while, then walked over to me, moving slowly until she was only inches away.

“Fredrick Fletcher, you are an interesting one.” Reaching out, she took the hook poking through my chest and snapped it clean off, almost effortlessly. I’d love to say the bend loosened it for her, but the implication was clear. She’d been partaking in more blood, probably even that of other parahumans, and was *much* stronger than I was. That’s the most dangerous thing about vampires—when we drink the blood of other parahumans, we absorb part of their ability. The strength and regeneration of therians is apparently a popular favorite, and the exact reason why so many of Richard’s staff look at me with distrust.

“Congratulations, Fredrick. You have saved this hunter’s life. I have no claim to kill him unless I am feeding, and you make the proposition of ingesting his blood a bit more than I’d like to gamble. That said, this sort of behavior cannot go unpunished.” Lillian walked back over to Colin, the hook of the harpoon clutched tightly in her hand. Her foot flipped him over, pointing his unconscious face toward the sky. Dragging the blade of the harpoon forcefully across her skin, she opened a small cut on her palm.

I realized what she was about to do only seconds before it happened, and by then, I was already too late. Lillian crouched down and pulled open Colin’s mouth, letting a few drops of her blood fall into his throat. That done, she carefully lowered his head back to the ground and looked up at me.

“Did . . . did you just make him a vampire?”

Lillian snorted, and as soon as she did, her eyes widened again. It was a brief moment, but it helped dispel a lot of the tension in the air. She’d slipped for a moment, letting me see that at least some of this “creature of the night” routine was for show. But the snort was gone, her face solemn again, and I chose to let the incident pass without comment.

“Fredrick, you really need to learn more about your own people. A vampire must drink a human’s blood, then give them some of their own in order for the change to occur. What I have offered is nothing more than a bit of magical booster, something to speed his healing along. Of course, if he does have silver in his system, that healing will be quite the painful experience. But he’ll survive, and be none the worse for wear. Eventually.”

Then she was up again, stepping over Colin and walking past me. From her pocket, she produced a small phone, one a bit sleeker than what I’d lost. Moving her thumb at exceptional speed, she clicked through several menus, tapped a few digital buttons, and offered the phone to me. “Something tells me you need this more than I do.”

“Thanks. Let me just look up the number and make a quick call—”

Lillian was already walking off though, shaking her head as she did. “Keep it; I’m due for an upgrade anyway. Plus, I wiped all the personal information. It’s yours now, for as long as you like.” She stopped, partway out of the alley, and looked out at the city of Winslow.

“You know, Fred, there are some interesting tales coming out of this city. Stories about one of our kind who’s like no other. They say he brokered a peace with the therians, courted an agent, and that even the King of the West calls him by name. Part of why my clan has come is to try and broker a meeting with him, if he even truly exists. Should we succeed, I’ll text that phone, perhaps even make an introduction. Someone like you could learn a lot from that sort of vampire.”

Then she was gone—well, from the alley at least—but her words lingered long after her, even as I looked up the number for Charlotte Manor and finally called my friends. People were telling stories about me? And not only that, they were getting all the details screwed up. My stomach twisted into a bundle of nerves, though I was technically out of harm’s way, and it wasn’t hard to figure out why.

After several years as a vampire, I was finally beginning to get a sense of when there was trouble on the horizon.

## 7.

“Well, the bad news is that your car is going to need some serious work. It looks like Colin punched out a window and shot the engine when you ran off, which isn’t surprising given the rage issues. Good news is that Bubba knows more than a few trustworthy mechanics, and the Agency is going to create an accident report where you aren’t at fault for your insurance company.” Krystal walked into the room, classically decorated and far from her style, not even pausing to kick off her boots before she dropped into bed next to me.

It hadn’t taken long after the call for Krystal to show up, along with Bubba, Richard, and Amy all packed into her truck. Arch drove his own car—a surprisingly well-maintained Cadillac that was easily older than anyone other than its driver. They’d managed to arrive quickly, but not quite before Colin had woken up screaming. As it turned out, my insane theory had actually panned out, and Colin had been putting silver in his bloodstream. Amy assured me that, with vampire blood in his system, he’d make a full recovery, but the next few hours would be tough. Not even she could lessen the pain, however, since silver would work against her magic as well.

After that, things sort of became a blur. Arch took Colin into custody, shoving him in the back of the Cadillac after cuffing him; though, with how much pain the hunter was in, the cuffs might have been unnecessary. The rest of the harpoon was yanked out of me, and I was brought back to Charlotte Manor, where Albert, Neil, and Sally were all waiting. Charlotte slipped a glass of wine into my hand the moment I entered, and I said a silent prayer of thanks for the hospitality of the possessed house. The rest of the gang went to my apartment, apparently sweeping it for traps, of which they found a few, and getting my car towed out of the street.

I don’t know how much time passed before Krystal returned, giving me a packet of blood from my fridge—silver free, she assured me—and escorting

me up to her new room. There hadn't even been time to unpack yet, so it felt oddly foreign. Part of me wished for the familiarity of my own home, or even Krystal's old apartment, but that sentiment faded as soon as I remembered that I was probably in the safest spot in all of Winslow. Once that hit home, I sucked down my blood and simply took the news as it rolled in. The car was the latest bit, the last of the truly pragmatic stuff, and as Krystal sank deeper into the cushy mattress, I turned over to meet her gaze.

"What's going to happen to Colin?"

"Depends on Colin," Krystal said. "From what we've been able to dig up so far, the guy lost his family to a vampire attack a few weeks back. Watched everyone die, but managed to drive a silver knife into the head of his attacker when it was his turn to go. His prints matched the ones at a scene we'd been trying to figure out for a while. Anyway, seeing that kind of shit will drive most people off the edge, and he's no exception."

She reached over, gently touching the part of my shoulder where the harpoon had burst through. There was no scar to mark it; in fact, if not for the torn shirt and sweater vest, it would have been impossible to tell that anything had ever happened.

"He's not bad, though. Got a natural talent for this sort of stuff. Never seen someone try to *carpo*on a vampire before."

"How long you been waiting to use that?" I asked.

"Hours. Had to make sure you were okay first, or it would have been in bad taste." She grinned, but we'd been together long enough that I could see the worry behind her smile. I'd been in trouble tonight, and she wasn't there to protect me. I imagined that was a hard pill to swallow, especially for an agent.

"Anyway, if Colin can be reformed, taught to understand that not all parahumans are bad, then maybe he could work off some of his time with the Agency. If he can't, then the cops are going to easily locate the dude who shot up a gas station, carjacked a taxi, and I'm sure pulled off a lot of other illegal stuff on other nights."

"What if he tells people about vampires?" I asked.

"Let him. He's not the first, and he won't be the last. Prisons have psych wards too these days." Krystal let go of my shoulder, wrapped her hand around my torso, and tapped me gently on the back. "Have to put him in a good one though. He's crafty. Did you know there was a GPS tracker on your back? Stuck right into your sweater vest."

My mind drifted back to when I was first running away, after the silver bullet failed to stop me. I remembered those next few shots. Loud, but not nearly as powerful. I'd taken them to be normal bullets at the time, but a small tracker made a lot more sense.

"Guess that's one mystery solved. I was wondering how he kept finding

me.” On the subject of being found, my brain lit up with a sudden rush of forgotten concern. “Oh crap, Dr. Huerta, is he okay?”

“He’s alive, and Amy is already talking with a few other local mages to get him fixed all the way up. They can even take away the memory, along with the rest of today, but so far he’s been refusing it. Also . . . I think Dr. Huerta is done with the blood trade,” Krystal said.

“Yeah. I sort of expected as much.” A white business card was suddenly a few inches from my nose, clutched in Krystal’s slender fingers. “What’s this?”

“You’re not the only vampire that prefers take-out. The Agency set up vendors centuries ago, ones who only buy blood at a fair rate. I never mentioned it, since they’re a bit pricier than what your guy was charging, but it seems pretty relevant as things stand. And they have a speedy delivery option.” She shook the card in front of me several more times, until I finally reached up and pulled it from her hand.

“They’re Agency-approved?”

“It’s better to say we keep an eye on them, and they know it,” Krystal replied. “They probably fudge a lot of paperwork here and there, but they’re smart enough not to try any big stuff. That one has a particularly good reputation. I asked around, in case it ever came up.”

“Thank you.” I slipped the card into my wallet, making a note to call them tomorrow. After I’d gotten a new phone. Much as I appreciated the assistance, I wasn’t sure I wanted to use a device that someone else had had such recent access to. It seemed senselessly dangerous. I put the wallet away and pulled out the phone, prompting a bit of throat-clearing from Krystal.

“So . . . about the vampire who helped you.”

“Lillian,” I said. “She said she was here for a meeting with the therians. I assume that means Richard.”

“Right. Well, we ran it down, and that part is mostly true. She’s part of a vampire clan that’s petitioning to meet with Richard. They want to move into town, but since Winslow is home to a lot of powerful therians, their badass leader, and the King of the West, coming in without at least an introduction would be a dicey proposal.”

“Let me guess, I only got away with it because I never hunted and kept my head down?”

“More or less,” Krystal said. “These things matter more with people who make a lot of waves, of which you are not one. Plus, you’re just one vampire. If therians see a whole clan suddenly appear without warning, they’re likely to think that the vampires are up to something. Maybe even an invasion to wrest control of the city. They tend to deal with those threats fast and hard.”

“Sort of encouraging that they want to go through proper channels, then,” I told her.



“We’ll see what we see.” Krystal shrugged, as if we were talking about whether our pizza would come with the proper toppings. It was hard to blame Krystal, though. While it seemed like a very dangerous situation to me, for her it likely wasn’t even a blip on the radar. I never dug too deep into what it was to be an agent, but the few glimpses I’d seen had left me with an appreciation for the scope of their duties, and their abilities.

“Lillian said there was another reason they wanted to talk with Richard.” I spoke carefully, not quite sure how best to broach this subject. In truth, I was still wrapping my own head around it, trying to convince myself that there was something I’d misunderstood. “She said they’d heard tales about a vampire who lived here. One who was on good terms with the therians, and dating an agent. Who was even not hated by the King of the West. I’m . . . I’m not crazy, am I? They’re talking about me.”

She looked at me for a long moment, then leaned in and kissed me gently on the forehead. “Yes and no, Freddy. Yes, parahumans love to talk—actually, who I am kidding, they love to *gossip*. But you know how those things go. Someone tells the story of catching a big fish, they leave out the hours of failure and trying different baits before the final success and cut right to the triumph. People chop the stories down to the interesting bits, pulling out the context. And without that context, some of the friendships you’ve made and things you’ve accomplished can seem almost inexplicable. So yes, the stories are about you in the sense that you have done those things, but no, they’re not about the Freddy that we all know and love. Did she even realize you were the one she wanted to meet?”

“Not in the slightest,” I replied. “In fact, she said someone like me could learn a lot from a vampire like that.”

“See, there you go. A few rumors flying around, but nothing to worry about. Kind of fun, in a way.” She reached up and poked my glasses, an affectation of familiarity and comfort rather than necessity. “You’re your own Clark Kent.”

“Except that my Superman is made up of gossip and mis-told stories,” I pointed out.

“And you don’t have the cape,” Krystal added.

“Whew, so you didn’t search my closet that carefully.” It was a joke, but Krystal’s smile faded a bit.

“About that, Freddy. You can’t go home for a few days,” she said. “Amy and I found more than a couple of booby traps in your apartment. Now, we’re both good, but given how resourceful Colin was, we decided it was safer to get the whole place professionally swept. Not to mention, anything we find might help us figure out who else Colin has attacked. Anyway, the long and short of it is that, for the next few days, your place is a crime scene.”

“That’s more than a little inconvenient.” I flipped back over, looking at the

wallpapered ceiling. “At least I can get a room from Charlotte.”

“Ooooooor . . .” Krystal drew out the word as she laid her head on my shoulder, the one not stained with blood. “We could take a vacation. Sort of. Arch needs to borrow Albert and Neil for something, but I’ve got vacation time saved up. What do you say we tag along? Get out of town for a little bit, let everything get settled.”

“I have a sneaking suspicion that this ‘vacation’ will just end with more peril, if Arch is taking Neil and Albert somewhere,” I told her.

“It’s not like that. This is networking. Arch thinks they’d do well to meet someone else who wields a weapon of destiny. No crimes need solving, no monsters need slaying. And if they did, the sheriff is more than capable of handling it.”

“That’s reassure—wait, sheriff? Where, exactly, are we going?”

Krystal looked up at me, a mischievous twinkle in her eye that I knew all too well meant things were about to get chaotic. “I’m going to take that as a ‘yes.’”

# A Sheriff in the Country

## 1.

The plane bounced a bit too enthusiastically upon landing and I reflexively grabbed Krystal's hand. While I am nervous about many things, flying isn't one of them. At least, normal flying isn't. The tiny little mechanism we sat in, supported only by a set of twin propellers, had proven to be a different story, though. I'd thought it would be quaint when I first laid eyes on it, something a little more classic than the monstrous jets that carry people around like cattle. What I didn't realize is that having a jet that big lessens the impact of turbulence, whereas in the small plane that brought me, Krystal, Arch, Albert, and Neil across the country, one could feel every single bump of turbulence along the way.

And there was a *lot* of turbulence between northern Colorado and east Texas. By the time the doors finally opened, showing me the beautiful freedom of a starlit night above, I nearly ripped my seatbelt in half vaulting out. Even if the sun had been shining, I might still have chanced it, preferring to burn to death in its deadly rays than risk another minute in those cramped, shaking quarters.

"Yeah, that's how most people react the first time they take this flight," Krystal noted, taking a much more sedate pace down the airplane's steep stairs, duffel bag slung over her shoulder. Albert was only a few steps behind, clad in his usual t-shirt and jeans, stringy hair pulled back tight. If not for the blade and gold hilt of a sword strapped to his back, there would be nothing to mark the passage of time since he first came to work for me. He was taking his time in the descent, helping Neil along. Of us all, the young mage was the only one without undead constitution or years of practice taking similar flights. He staggered down the stairs, still looking green in the face despite

filling up no less than three “sanitation” bags during the flight. Though the two of us were rarely on good terms, my heart went out to him. If vampires could vomit, I almost certainly would have matched his record.

Arch was the last to leave, pausing to say a few quick words to the pilot. No sooner had he gotten outside than he reached into the pocket of his dark, functional slacks and pulled out a pack of cigarettes. I’d never known anyone who smoked more than Arch, or took less joy in it. It was an especially curious affectation given how crisp and precise everything else about him was, from his close-cut hair to the carefully concealed weapons all over his body. My best bet was that it had something to do with his parahuman nature. As far I could tell, Arch looked human—a young human, at that—but given his reputation and status with the Agency, I knew there was something I was missing.

“Been too long,” Arch said, making his way down the stairs. I wasn’t sure if he was talking about the cigarette or our destination, though the former seemed far more likely.

As near as I could tell, we’d landed in an abandoned field. At the far edge, I could see a shack made of sheet metal, and the runway the plane had used was well-kept, but nothing about our surroundings marked this as an airport. Which was probably why we’d had to take a special plane from the Agency in the first place.

From the edge of the clearing, I picked up a pair of lights moving toward us. A car, or maybe a truck; hard to tell from so far off, even with my eyes. It would be a while before it arrived, so I wheeled around on Krystal.

“We’re here.”

“Very good, Freddy. That is what the landing means.” She was being glib, knowing quite well what I was driving at and taking joy in stringing me along.

“I feel I’ve been a pretty good sport about this, especially when you told me that you wanted our vacation to take place in rural Texas, but we had a deal. Once we arrive, you’re supposed to tell me what’s so special about this place.” I conjured my very best “I mean business” face, which only managed to draw a few giggles from her and a half-hearted snicker from Neil, who immediately had to cover his mouth.

“All they told me was that there was someone else with a weapon, and I should meet them,” Albert offered. Unlike me, he didn’t mind being kept in the dark. Of course, he’d also come here with a purpose. As someone who had drawn a weapon of destiny, Albert was trying to learn how to use it, as well as figure out what he wanted to do with it. Speaking to someone who was on the same path could offer him a lot of insight. He, Arch, and Neil all had good reason to come out to the boonies. I just couldn’t fathom what was so special about this place that Krystal insisted I *had* to see it.

“My plan was to let you see the place for yourself, but fine, if you really want to be a spoilsport, I’ll tell you.” Krystal held up her hands and gestured to the empty fields. “Freddy, welcome to the edge of Boarback, Texas. One of only three openly parahuman settlements in all of the United States.”

“Excuse me, open settlements?” While I had a hunch at what she was saying, it seemed more prudent to get confirmation.

“It’s just what it sounds like,” Arch jumped in. “Boarback is a town where parahumans live in the open. All of the inhabitants are either parahuman or regular humans that have been brought here intentionally. We keep it off maps, the roads to get in are almost impassable unless you know the secret routes, and everything around here is wiped from satellite imagery. No one accidentally discovers this town. And because of that, there’s no hiding. Everyone can be exactly what they are.”

“That’s . . . incredible.” While I wish I’d come up with something a bit more eloquent, at that moment my mind was simply reeling too much for me to state anything other than the most obvious prattle. A whole town, a civilization of parahumans who weren’t trying to blend in with human society. Granted, I was a big fan of human society, and aside from the dietary restrictions and sunlight issues, considered myself very much a part of it. However, my time with Krystal had let me glimpse other sides of the parahuman world, beings who had to go to much greater extremes to blend in. I’d always assumed that was the only option presented to them, but now, I’d just taken a bumpy plane ride to one I’d never imagined.

“Incredible, and necessary,” Krystal said. “Try as we might to make them, there are some parahumans who just refuse to keep a low profile. They aren’t dangerous or anything; some do it by accident, others out of stubbornness. Point is, they don’t deserve jail, but we can’t let them wander around with humans, either. This was the compromise someone came up with in the early days. Boarback was the first, and when it worked, they added more.”

“Many choose to live here, now. Prefer it to spending a life among a species that can only fear them.” Arch finished his first cigarette, tucking it neatly into the box of ash and stubs he always carried, and immediately began another. In the distance, I could finally make out the shape of the approaching vehicle. Definitely a truck; though, given the terrain it was driving over, that seemed a practical choice.

“It’s pretty incredible. Everything is parahuman friendly. All the buildings have enchanted glass, just for the sun allergic, and there are underground tunnels to get around during the day. The library is full of ancient tomes for mages to study—along with a healthy romance section, from the invoices I’ve seen—and all the different dietary needs are accounted for. The Agency makes monthly drops to ensure food sources are on hand.” Krystal was actually rocking on her heels in excitement. I’d initially thought she was

dragging me along just for kicks, but the longer she spoke, the more I realized how much she genuinely loved this place.

“If there are that many parahumans, it seems like it would be hard to keep the peace.” Neil slowly tried to let go of Albert and stand on his own. Despite a shaky start, he managed to stay on his feet. “Do you keep agents posted here all the time or something?”

Krystal shook her head, smiling so big I could almost see her back teeth. “No need. Boarback has its own police force; a sheriff and a couple of deputies. In fact, one of those deputies is who you’re here to meet, Albert. Those two alone are more than enough to handle most of the trouble that crops up in a town this size. But if there’s ever anything serious, the sheriff will step in and deal with it.”

“Is he a former agent or something?” I asked.

“He’s something, all right.” Arch’s words were muttered, not so soft that he was trying to conceal them, but soft enough to not be part of the conversation. Krystal reached over and punched her fellow agent in the shoulder before turning back to me.

“Don’t mind Arch. He just doesn’t like losing.”

“It was hardly a fair fight,” Arch said.

“When are any of your fights fair? Isn’t that the first thing you teach rookies to expect?” Krystal leered at him willfully, until Arch turned away and silently took another drag from his second cigarette. “To answer your question, Freddy, no, I don’t think Sheriff Thorgood was ever officially an agent, but he has a lot of ties to the Agency. We send our more problematic cases—people who’ve just turned and don’t know how to control their power yet—out here for him to look after.”

And with that, I finally realized why Krystal was so excited to show me this patch-of-nowhere town. “They sent you here, didn’t they? This is where you first trained.”

“Only until I got the hang of using my skills, and made peace with the whole ‘devil living inside me’ stuff. After that, they put me in the regular program. But I spent a while in Boarback, learning from the sheriff.”

With near perfect timing, the truck finished its forward journey, coming to a halt approximately twenty feet away from us. The passenger door popped open, and a man stepped out. He was big, by normal standards; though, after meeting men like Richard, my scale was somewhat skewed. Visually, he wasn’t terribly impressive, akin to a shorter, less muscular version of Bubba, and he wore a beige policeman’s uniform, complete with matching cowboy hat. His stomach hadn’t quite reached the point of lapping over his gun belt, but it was a battle that could be lost any day. Large hands spread out as he stretched his arms wide (revealing a gold sheriff’s badge on his chest) and motioned to Krystal.

“Is that Agent Jenkins? Get over here and give your old teacher a hug.”

That was all the prompting it took, as Krystal raced forward and the two embraced. It was surprisingly familial, a sentiment I didn’t see in my girlfriend very often. Rather than a teacher, it looked like she was being bear-hugged by an uncle. Finally, they released, and he began making his way around to the rest of us.

“Arch, you better finish that damn thing before you get in my truck, or I’ll hitch you to back and let you run for it.” He slapped Arch on the back as he spoke, nearly knocking the agent’s cigarette from his hand. “And you must be Albert, the zombie who pulled out the Blade of the Unlikely Champion. Pleasure to meet you, son.” He held out his big paw of a hand and Albert shook it, looking more like he was hanging on than participating.

“Which makes you Neil, the apprentice, sorry, journeyman learning from Mage Wells. That’s some big shoes to fill; I hope you’re working hard.” He grabbed Neil’s hand and gave it a shake as well, moving so fast that even the usually brooding necromancer didn’t have a chance to come up with something glib to say.

I watched all these exchanges in sheer wonder, marveled by what a touch the sheriff had with people. Despite being in what could be argued was literally Nowhere, he lacked the same southern twang I’d gotten so accustomed to with Bubba. Instead, his accent was neutral, and hard to even grasp beneath the warmth and volume of his words. Hard as I tried to pin it down, there was just some sort of charisma about him that made the sheriff seem inherently likeable. Now *that* was an ability I wouldn’t have minded getting when I went vampire.

“And that just leaves you, the vampire that I hear is dating one of my students.” He turned toward me and closed the distance between us in only a few steps. For having such an ambling gait, he moved surprisingly fast. “Anyone Krystal trusts enough to bring around is good people in my book. Pleasure to meet you; I’m the sheriff of Boarback, Leeroy Thorgood.”

“Fredrick Fletcher,” I replied, reaching for his hand. “But most people call me Fred.”

The moment Sheriff Thorgood took my hand, a whole new sensation washed over me. I’ve mentioned before about how a primal part of my vampire brain sees the world in terms of predators and prey, and how catatonic I went upon meeting Gideon, an apex predator, for the first time. This wasn’t quite the same, in that I didn’t start babbling or fall over. In fact, I don’t think my instincts saw the sheriff as predator or prey. They didn’t know what to make of him. He didn’t fit anywhere into my base vampire understanding of the world. The one thing I did know about him, that I could feel rippling off the man in physical waves, was that he was *powerful*. And I say that having glimpsed the true capabilities of an ancient dragon.

“Glad to meet you.” If Leeroy noticed my reaction, he didn’t let it show. Instead, he gave my hand a few pumps, then released it and nodded to the truck. “Suns up in a few hours. Let’s get your bags and head into town.”



## 2.

Despite the bleakness of their airport, I was pleasantly surprised to find the town of Boarback to be more than ten houses and a general store that doubled as a church and gas station. If that sounds ridiculous, allow me to remind you that Krystal and I grew up in a rural farming town. While ours wasn't quite that bad, there were others not too far off that dearly wished they could get up to ten houses. Such was not the case with Boarback, however.

Instead, Sheriff Thorgood pulled his truck along dusty, nearly invisible roads, one after the other, until we broke through a tree line and into a scene that looked like it was stolen from the mid-1900s. We were staring down what appeared to be an old-fashioned main street, complete with a worn, brick-paved road. Shops lined the block on both sides, which was curiously absent of cars. A few were about, but nowhere near as many as I saw in Winslow on any given block.

Other roads, leading to businesses that were too large to fit on the central street, branched off at regular intervals. But what struck me immediately was a fact that I should have expected: nothing was a chain store. Every business I could see, from "Grixxle's Repair" to "Uros Massage and Spa" to a squat yellow building that just said "Diner" was obviously independent. It was sort of funny, to me at least, that there were thousands of people all over the nation who wanted to go back to the "good ole days," and here it was, exactly as described. Except for the fact that almost everyone who lived here was pulled straight from the myths and nightmares of humanity.

The second thing to strike me was how busy the town was, in spite of the late hour. Now, I know vampires and other undead are all mostly nocturnal by nature, but I hadn't expected that trait to apply to every parahuman. Yet here they were, walking up and down the street, waving at the truck as Sheriff Thorgood drove by. Many of them were humanesque, perhaps with an odd

horn here or animal eyes there, but some were so far removed from human that I wondered how they would have ever gotten along in the normal world.

Four small creatures with green skin, batlike ears, and overalls were walking past a centaur who was scribbling furiously in a worn notebook. Near the edge of the road, a small blonde woman and her daughter were both holding hands with a furry brown parahuman who was at least ten feet tall. His hands were so big, in fact, that I realized they were holding his thick fingers. And I say “he” because a pair of gray slacks covered the lower part of his body, so I was assuming that was where modesty kicked in. Not too far off from the trio was something I could barely wrap my head around, a being who seemed to be formed entirely out of molding clay with its face pressed up against the window of a shop. And yes, I mean literally pressed, which was what gave away the malleable consistency of its brown body.

“Holy hell.” For a rare change, Neil and I were in agreement, though he was the one who voiced the words. Albert seemed dumbstruck as well, all of us staring out the truck’s open windows in what I would later realize was incredibly impolite gawking.

“I never realized there were so many types of parahumans,” I said, finally marshalling some control of myself. “Even at CalcuCon, there wasn’t this much variety.”

“The cons are fun, but not everyone can travel easily.” It might have been my imagination, but Arch seemed a bit grumpier than usual, probably because he’d been forbidden from smoking in the sheriff’s truck. “Besides, those only attract parahumans looking to do business or meet up with others like them. They’re little islands of community in a sea of pretending to be human. These people don’t have that need. They’re always connected to the parahuman world.”

“Yeah, they are.” Albert hadn’t quite reached the point of hanging his head out the window, but I put a hand on his shoulder anyway, just in case. I understood the reaction. Even for beings like us, who could blend in with little effort, the strain of always pretending, always staying careful and aware, was like a weight we carried around.

As we drove up the road and pulled into the sheriff’s office, I felt that weight lift for the first time in years. This wasn’t a con where walls, tenuous and easily breached, had been erected to keep our secrets safe. Here, the world was truly kept at bay, and in this town, there was no need to pretend. We weren’t the oddities. We were just . . . people.

Sheriff Thorgood killed the engine and hauled himself out of the car, the rest of us following his lead. The office was a brick building, larger than I’d initially expected. Then I remembered the size of the furry man in gray slacks, and suddenly I could see why space might be important here. We walked inside to find a large central room with three desks, and a row of five cells at

the back of the building. None were occupied, though they all had fresh blankets and a pillow resting on them just in case. Near the rear of the room, a small television was tuned into a baseball game on mute. Evidently, we'd caught someone relaxing before we pulled up.

There were two, and only two, candidates for who might be the baseball fan. Standing in the center of the office area, like they'd been waiting for us, were a man and a woman, both dressed in the same beige uniform as Sheriff Thorgood. The man had dark, spiky hair with what appeared to be red highlights, along with a lean frame and a sharp stare. The woman seemed entirely human, save for her eyes, which were bright yellow and a little too big for her face. Leeroy stepped forward and clapped his hands on both of their shoulders as he made introductions.

"Folks, I'd like you to meet the rest of the Boarback Sherriff's Department. The fellow who puts too much mousse in his hair is Deputy Ixen, though you can just call him Nax. And this bright-eyed young woman is Deputy Saunders, though she just goes by Sable. For that matter, I don't want to hear anyone calling me sheriff. I'm just Leeroy to friends. Nax, I think you're the only one who has met Agent Jenkins."

"Just Krystal, I get enough of that 'Agent Jenkins' shit in the field." Krystal nodded at Nax, who met her gaze for only a brief moment. "Good to see you again, kid. Uniform suits you better than cuffs."

"Joining Krystal today is her fellow agent, Arch; her boyfriend Fred; and the pair that came to meet Sable, Neil and Albert." Leeroy pointed at each of us as he went down the list of names, making sure Nax and Sable knew who was who.

"So, you've got one too." Sable started forward, coming close to Albert and then walking a bit past him to check out the sword strapped to his back. The black-and-gold scabbard that matched the hilt of his blade rested there, fixed in a harness that Arch had designed himself. Since moving to Winslow, the agent had been training my assistant on proper sword-wielding three evenings a week, and every other weekend. While no one was asking Albert to go out and start picking fights with his blade, it was agreed all around that him being at least somewhat proficient was in everyone's best interest.

"Blade of the Unlikely Champion," Albert told her, slowly drawing his sword from its sheath. The weapon almost hummed as it moved through the air, more magic than steel, or so we'd been told. Given that I'd seen him cut through the very enchantment that held a chimera together, turning it back into its base animals, I had no reason to doubt the assessment of Albert's blade.

"That is a pretty one." Sable walked across the room and reached behind one of the desks, pulling out a large single-bladed axe. It, too, was strapped into a harness, and she effortlessly pulled the weapon free from the straps and

cover concealing its blade. “Mine is the Axe of the Forsaken Child. Obviously, it doesn’t have the gentlest of requirements to wield, but it packs a hell of a wallop.”

She spun the weapon easily, her years of training visible in the fluid grace of her movements. Bringing it to a stop, the bone-white blade extended outward, she moved the head of her axe closer, bit by bit, to the humming steel of Albert’s sword. Carefully, she tapped the edge of his blade against her own, and a soft, melodic tone echoed around us.

“Looks like these two get along.” Sable pulled back her axe and slipped it into its harness once more. “Sometimes they can be finicky, if the destiny of each wielder is in conflict. Good news, Albert. Looks like you and I aren’t meant to fight each other.”

“I didn’t even realize that was a possibility,” Albert said.

“All of these things are trying to drag their owners somewhere,” Sable replied. “How much we let them is on us, but there are many out there that are working toward different ends. When they touch, you don’t get a pretty chime, trust me.”

“Now that everyone, animated and otherwise, has been introduced, what’s say we go get some grub?” Leeroy suggested.

“Actually, I wouldn’t mind dropping off my bags and showering first,” Krystal interrupted. “I was sitting a little closer to Neil than the rest of us on that flight.”

The necromancer’s face went flush and he lowered his head. “Sorry.”

“Not a problem. I’ve gotten far worse on me in the line of duty. Still, wouldn’t say no to a good scrubbing.”

“All right, we’ll go to the inn, let everyone unwind and unpack, and then off to the diner,” Leeroy acquiesced. “Tonight’s special is chicken fried steak, and I’d have to arrest myself for the crime of letting you folks miss it if they run out.”

“It’s a CFS night? Hot damn, I’ll shower fast.” Krystal grabbed my hand and dragged me back out into the street, where she began shoveling the bags at me so fast that I didn’t get the chance to ask her why she was taking things *out* of the truck if we were about to leave the station.

### 3.

As it turned out, the reason Krystal had dragged all our bags out of Leeroy's truck was that there was no need to get back in the vehicle to reach the inn. The Bristle Inn, Boarback's one and only place of lodging, was within walking distance of the station. In fact, everything within the town square was walkable. While cars were needed to reach some of the neighborhoods and single homes further away, once a traveler was on the main street—which I learned was actually called Sunshine Lane—they needed only shoe leather to make it to any other destination.

The walk to the inn took around ten minutes, but it would have been five if Neil's slower gait hadn't caused everyone else to match his pace. Part of the comparative slowness was that he was one of the few humans in the group, magic-slinging skills notwithstanding, but it was also due to the fact that studying tomes of ancient magic wasn't an activity that did much for cardio.

I'd expected the Bristle Inn to be like Charlotte Manor, quaint and dated, but in fact, it turned out to be one of the more modern buildings in town. Once we got to our room, a spacious area with a king-sized bed and a flat-screen, Krystal had explained that since Boarback got more than a few visitors in the form of agents and general parahumans, they'd invested in a nice place for people to stay. That was all she could muster before slipping into the shower, the water running so hot I could see the edge of the mirror beginning to fog within minutes.

While she showered, I unpacked my own small suitcase and changed into what I considered my more outdoors-y attire: jeans, sneakers, and a short-sleeve button down paired with a robin's egg blue sweater-vest. My more formal clothes were quickly folded and carefully put away, which still left me with time to kill before Krystal finished her shower.

Pulling out my laptop, I was pleasantly surprised to find a Wi-Fi signal in

our room, which I immediately jumped onto and began checking my e-mail. It had only been a day since the Colin incident, where I was hunted all over Winslow—a day which I’d spent hunkered down in Charlotte Manor with a laptop retrieved from my apartment, trying desperately to carve out a bit of breathing room in my work schedule. It helped that Krystal was busy setting up the trip, and that some of my parahuman clients understood that being hunted by an insane human can throw off a schedule. Still, I was barely treading water, so anything I could get done in the small bits of spare time I had would be a big help. Things were reaching a tipping point though, there was no getting around that. Either Fletcher Accounting Services would have to expand, or I’d have to start turning down work, a prospect which utterly galled me.

It’s impossible to say how long I was working before I heard Krystal’s voice making a “tsk” sound and saw a polished red fingernail begin to tip my screen forward, closing the laptop even as I hurriedly tried to save my progress.

“I did not book us this place so you could work.”

“You booked it because it’s the only hotel in town,” I countered, mercifully clicking the outdated icon of a floppy disk and shutting the laptop myself. “Good internet, too.”

“This place isn’t as podunk as you might expect.” Krystal grinned at me, and I noticed for the first time what outfit she’d changed into. A red flannel shirt tied off at the stomach, jean shorts that were far from Daisy-dukes but still quite higher than her usual sweats or slacks, all topped off with a beat-up straw hat perched atop her blonde head.

“You’re making such a clear case for that,” I replied.

“What, you’re the only one who gets to dress more comfortably?” Krystal asked.

“I was actually just wondering where you were going to hide your gun.” I nodded to the black belt and attached holster lying on the bed where she’d left them. Inside was her firearm, the one accessory Krystal never left home without. Earlier in the relationship, I’d considered the practice paranoid. After a few months, I wondered why she didn’t carry two.

“That thing will totally throw off my outfit. It can stay in the room. I’ll hang a ‘Do Not Disturb’ so no one will come in and fuck with it.” Krystal turned, picked up her firearm, and set it to the side, completely missing the look of shock on my face. Fortunately, it was still there by the time she turned back, or at least, I assume it was, because she gave me a world-class roll of the eyes. “What?”

“You *never* leave your gun behind. Bubba took us night fishing, and you wore that gun belt over a bikini. I’ve seen you take it with you when you run downstairs to get mail. Can you blame me for being a little surprised?”

“I suppose I do have a bit of an attachment,” Krystal admitted. “That’s just prudence in my line of work. But it’s not necessary here.”

“Why not?” There was something in her eyes, something she was hiding. When it came to her job, Krystal was probably a master deceiver, but in her personal life, she so rarely said anything other than the blunt truth that it became obvious when she was trying to choose her words.

“Because in this town, we’re safe.” Krystal walked back into the bathroom, pulling out her toiletries kit and grabbing a stick of deodorant. “Aside from the petty bullshit that any place has, there’s no real crime here. No outside threats, either. You probably got a hint of how strong Leeroy is, and his deputies are no joke. Boarback is peaceful. Fun, too. After the diner, if there’s time before sunrise, we’ll hike up to Cervain’s Lake. It’s so clear you can see the moon’s reflection like you’re looking into the sky.”

Nice as that sounded, I still couldn’t help but feel like she was changing the subject, though from what, I had no idea. There was just something defensive about her excitement, like she was trying extra hard to sell me on how much she loved this place.

“And during the day, we can take the tunnels around to check out the shops. They’ve got all kinds of unique items here, handmade, the stuff you’d have to special order in the outside world. Some of the craftsmen out here are incredible; we hire them as independent contractors for the Agency sometimes. Of course, given our reputation, not many take us up on it, even with all the perks doing contract work provides. Oh, and everything is parahuman owned, obviously. They get a pretty good deal on land and lodging out here, so it’s a big sell for starting local businesses.”

At last, it all fell into place. There were many things about which Krystal would happily talk with neither prompting nor explanation, but the viability of starting a small business was not one of them. That was for my benefit, and I could only see one reason why she would bother to give me such information.

“Krystal,” I said, walking over so that she could see me from the bathroom. “I do run my own company, you know. I’m perfectly aware of what a sales pitch sounds like.”

The deodorant paused, all the confirmation I needed, then she let out a sigh and finished applying. Putting the cap back on the white chalky stick, she faced me, a rare solemn expression on her face. “This is a good town, Fred. Lots of parahumans with businesses who could use a talented accountant. Internet to let you work with your old clients. Nice, quiet people who want what you’ve always wanted: a normal, peaceful life.”

“And no hunters suddenly showing up to try and kill me,” I added.

“You think that’s why I’m trying to sell you on Boarback? Fred, that guy was a chump. If you’d had to, you could have taken him apart. He’s not—”

Her words halted, and she looked away from me, just for a few seconds. “You know the vampire who made you, Quinn, was a real rat bastard, right?”

“Seeing as he tried to kill all of us and successfully ripped your throat out, I won’t be jumping to his aid anytime soon,” I said.

“Well, it turns out that he was also a real, territorial rat bastard. The reason we’ve seen so little vampire activity in Winslow is because it was considered Quinn’s, and he didn’t like to share. But word got out that he finally went too far and stepped against the Agency, so now he’s on the run. That means other vampires have begun moving back in, retaking the territory that Quinn used to hold. Places like Winslow.” Krystal walked over to the pants she’d traveled in and began digging through the pockets.

“I don’t understand, is that why you want me to relocate? Fear of other vampires? You’ve gone out of your way to tell me that we’re not all bad, that you work with several who are good people. Why does more vampires coming to town automatically make you want to hide me away?”

“Plenty of vampires *are* decent people,” Krystal replied, finally locating her phone and yanking it out from the pocket it was lodged in. “But you know who usually aren’t? The ones who go around seizing another vampire’s territory after he goes on the lamb. Those are the ambitious types, and they play by the belief that if you aren’t with them, you’re against them. The rumor mill worked its magic, and now lots of people know there’s another vampire in Winslow, Colorado, one who has pulled off a whole lot of impressive stuff. That’s the sort of situation where the new vamps either have to make you join, or get you out of the picture.”

“Wait, you think they’ll kill me just for living in my own town?” My voice may have leapt up a few degrees on that one. I’d gotten used to the idea that the parahuman world was a less restrained one than what humans dealt with, but offing someone just because they lived in a town you were moving to seemed a bit extreme.

“Most likely, they’d compel you to join, but you’re a smart guy. You can probably beat them at the strategy game. So then, they’ll wait for an opportunity to use a loophole in the treaties, one that lets them take offense with you. After that, they can challenge you for honor, and if you happen to die in the process, then so be it.” Krystal held her phone tightly, the edges of her fingers beginning to turn white from force. “I’ve seen it happen before. And if they do it, Freddy, then I can’t protect you. I’m an agent, and that means I have to work within the laws and treaties. I’ll have to stand there and just . . . watch.”

Moving slowly, I wrapped my arms around her and gave her a small kiss on the top of her head. Tough as Krystal was, powerful as the monster inside made her, I knew she’d said early goodbyes to too many loved ones in her life.



“That’s a lot of ‘ifs’ and ‘maybes,’” I told her. “While I’m not exactly thrilled about new vampires moving to town, we don’t know that I’ll be a target. What the vampire people are gossiping about might be something, but I’m just an accountant. There’s a good chance they won’t even care about me.”

“Not as good as you think.” Krystal turned on her phone, the glow lighting her face from below, and made a few swipes before finding what she was looking for. Stepping back from my embrace, she handed me the phone, which I picked up slowly. “That request was put in the night you met Lillian. Came less than an hour after we’d picked you up.”

Before me was an e-mail, from an address that was unrecognizable, alerting Agent Jenkins that her romantic partner, Fredrick Fletcher, had been named in a formal information request between the House of Turva and Richard Alderson. It mentioned a lot of things I didn’t understand, negotiation dates and reference numbers, but those details were irrelevant. What mattered was my name, and the people who wanted to know more about me.

“You’re on their radar,” Krystal said, likely reading the comprehension on my face. “And sooner or later, that’s a thing that will require dealing with. Richard’s a friend, and he’s not going to tell them anything you wouldn’t want known, but you run a public business, Freddy. It won’t take much to learn who you are and where you live. Maybe it’s idle curiosity, maybe they want some taxes done, but not everyone is as kind-hearted as you. I’ve seen these things turn before, and if they’re handled carefully enough, then we agents don’t have any recourse.”

I sat down on the bed, my own body suddenly feeling very heavy. “I can’t just leave town, though. What about our friends?”

“Albert and Neil can come with us.” Krystal sat down next to me, gently taking her phone out of my hands. “This is where Arch wanted to bring them in the first place. Plenty of space and time to train, plus a fellow weapon-wielder to spar with. Bubba and Amy would stay in Winslow—he’s been climbing the ladder with Richard, and she’s too deeply rooted to just up and leave—but they’d still be able to visit us. Amy’s wares alone could sell enough to justify the trip.”

“Us?” I stopped staring at my empty hand and faced Krystal, who was only a few inches away. “You said us. Does that mean you’d come, too?”

“You know how my job works; it doesn’t matter much where I call home. And I’m already packed up anyway. Plus, I love Boarback. I wouldn’t mind coming home to it at the end of my missions, especially if my boyfriend was already here waiting for me.” Krystal leaned in closer, wrapping her arms around my shoulders. “I was going to ease you into this, Freddy, not come on right away with the hard sell. We’ve got a day and a half left here, so just think it over. Take the town in; imagine what it would be like to live here.

That's all I'm asking."

"I'll keep an open mind." I kissed her, partly out of affection, partly because I genuinely had no idea what else to say. Krystal made good points, and if she thought there was reason to worry, then I had no doubt there was. Still, Winslow was my home, and while I've never been ashamed to admit that I am a coward by nature, the idea of being forced out of my town left a hard pit in my stomach.

But that feeling was nothing compared to the wave of nerves that washed over me when I imagined an entire clan of vampires, all of them Quinn in my head, discussing exactly how to deal with a vampire already operating on their turf.

## 4.

By the time we'd composed ourselves and made it downstairs, the others were already waiting, so we cut a quick pace to the diner. Though I asked, and everyone agreed it had once had a more formal name, the moniker had been lost somewhere in the sands of time. For as long as anyone could remember, it was just "the diner," and when we arrived, I found those simple words written at the top of the laminated menus. With the yellow-painted walls and overstuffed red booths, it could have easily fit in off any highway exit in America, save for the staff and clientele.

Since arriving at the sheriff's office, I'd somewhat forgotten the spectacle of driving down Sunshine Lane and seeing all the different parahumans out and about. But the realization of just how far out of normal bounds we were came rushing back the moment our waitress slithered over to us. That was not creative language, by the way. Our waitress, Yenny (as she introduced herself), was a fairly normal-looking woman with brown hair and eyes a pale shade of orange. She wore a yellow shirt with white trim that matched the restaurant's walls, and nothing else. I don't mean to imply anything lude, it's simply that Yenny's bottom half was that of a bright orange snake's tail.

Mercifully, I wasn't the only one who was a bit surprised, as Neil wouldn't quit staring and Albert dropped his menu to the floor as soon as he saw her. Yenny took it surprisingly well, glossing over their shock with warm greetings, and then getting down to the business of what we'd be eating.

Ordering was a quick affair. Leeroy declared that the chicken fried steak was the best thing to be had, and he was seconded by Krystal, Nax, and Sable. With no point of reference for anything else, and a keen eye that noticed some of the menu items were clearly designed for parahumans rather than mundane palettes (unless raw sparrow eggs and powdered coal were delicacies I'd somehow missed), it made sense to trust the group consensus.

In spite of the heavy burden weighing on my mind, dinner was an enjoyable affair. Periodically, new parahumans would get up from their seats or walk in, which gave us peeks at the creatures we'd never laid eyes on before. Leeroy entertained the whole table with stories of the town's history and the various incidents he'd been called on to help with over the years. I'd never considered the possibility that a troll could hibernate, grow, and end up stuck under a bridge, but as Leeroy recounted having to borrow farm equipment to get the fellow unstuck, it seemed like the most natural thing in the world. Even Arch chuckled a few times, when he wasn't outside taking his cigarettes.

I would also be remiss if I glossed over the food, which was incredible. Chicken fried steak was hardly a new cuisine for me—nor most anyone, I'd imagine—but sometimes the simplest dishes are the best when every element is handled perfectly. From the first bite of spiced meat, crisp crust, and decadent gravy, I understood why Leeroy had insisted we not miss this special. I would have bitten through a hundred dirty tires for a meal like that, and once again, I was grateful I had retained my taste buds despite being undead.

The experience as a whole was oddly serene, at least for me. Ever since reconnecting with Krystal at our high school reunion, I'd been drawn progressively deeper and deeper into the parahuman world. And while many of those experiences helped me meet important people in my life, they also all tended to be fraught with chaos, if not outright peril. So somewhere in my brain, I suppose I had made the connection that the more parahumans one was around, the more hectic and dangerous things would be. But here we were, eating chicken fried steak an hour before dawn, in a town filled almost exclusively with other parahumans, and it was one of the more peaceful moments of my last few years. It didn't even feel like we were all vampires and zombies and other inhuman species. It just felt like sitting around with a bunch of friends.

By the time the food was eaten and we were heading back to the inn to beat the sun, I'd begun to consider the possibility that living in Boarback could have its merits. True, one meal did not a happy life make, but I'd promised to keep an open mind, and it was hard to deny that the town did have a charm all its own. I was so lost in thought, and in observation of the people walking up and down Sunshine Lane, that I didn't even hear Arch speak. Krystal nudged me in the ribs, and I turned to find the vertically challenged agent staring at me, clearly waiting for a response.

"Sorry, what was that?"

Arch didn't roll his eyes, yet somehow, he still gave off the same feeling as if he had. "I was letting you know that I'm going to be borrowing Albert and Sable for a training session while those who need it grab a nap. Since you

don't need sleep, I offered to let you come along and watch. Though, at the moment, I'm rethinking the wisdom of that decision."

"I'd love to, but . . ." I glanced up at the sky, which was already growing gray as the stars faded, declaring retreat against the overwhelming forces of daytime.

"This place is underground," Arch assured me. "Sunlight restrictions aside, it's more prudent to have a training facility away from prying eyes. Despite how Mayberry this place might look, it was founded as a sanctuary, and nobody knows the importance of a place to hide like parahumans."

Arch's reference to Mayberry caught me off guard, although it shouldn't have. I often forgot that though he looked comparable in age to Neil and Albert, he'd been alive for at least a century, or so I guessed from what I'd gotten through context. He never discussed his exact age, and I made a point not to pry where agents were concerned.

"I like to think of it more as a place to shelter while problems are handled," Leeroy added. "But it works just fine for sparring grounds and a gym these days."

After a moment's consideration, I nodded. "Sure, I'll tag along. I'd like to see as much of Boarback as possible. That's what I'm here for." I gave Krystal a quick kiss, which she used as an opportunity to show approval of my choice by squeezing my, um, rear, and then bid farewell as she and Neil began heading up to the Bristle Inn.

"I'll show you all down there." Leeroy headed toward the police station, while I marveled at the fact that he hadn't said "y'all," despite the rustic surroundings. The sheriff of Boarback might live here, but he definitely didn't hail from this region of the world. Then again, with how long some parahumans lived, it was entirely possible that the place he'd called home didn't exist anymore. Countries fell all the time, back in the older days of history.

Nax walked with us to the station, then peeled off as he proclaimed that "someone had to be on duty," and that, by process of elimination, that was him. Duty didn't seem that bad, though, as he immediately went to his desk in the middle of the room and kicked up his feet, eyes on the old television in the corner.

We were taken through one of the doors near the back of the station, which led to a staircase. This wasn't a small set that took us a basement, however. These were slick, worn, and went on for so long that not even I could see the bottom, which was not a common occurrence. All of us proceeded down, Leeroy in the lead, followed by Sable, then Albert, then me, with Arch bringing up the rear. While some neurotic part of me wondered if he was taking the back position in case we were threatened from behind, the more logical part of me had a hunch that it was because these steps were a

little slippery, and if anyone went tumbling, they'd take his smaller frame down with them.

It was impossible to gauge how far down we'd gone by the time we reached the bottom. I only knew that I wasn't too worried about stray beams of sunlight getting in anymore. Leeroy yanked a lever near the bottom of the stairs, and a new set of bulbs flickered on, hung at irregular intervals through the rough corridors sprawled out before us. They seemed to twist and turn in all directions, but Leeroy didn't hesitate as he continued on, taking us through one turn after another until we arrived at our destination.

The cavern was vast—by underground measures, at any rate. It was roughly half the size of a football field, with a domed ceiling that rose twenty feet in the air. A small rack of weaponry—swords and maces and the like—was set up at the end furthest from the entrance. Halfway between the rack and the way in were what looked an awful lot like benches etched into the very stone of the cavern.

"No way this is natural." I didn't mean to say the words out loud, but the sound of Leeroy's chuckle informed me of my slip-up.

"You hit the nail on the head," he said, grabbing me by the shoulder and leading me over to the benches while Arch took Albert and Sable toward the middle of the cavern. "Artificially carved, save for a few of the tunnels near the entrances that were used as a starting point."

"Was this made for the town?"

Leeroy gave his large head a mighty shake. "Other way around. Part of why we picked this spot was because these tunnels were here. They were originally home to . . . well, maybe you're happier not knowing. Something that had to be rooted out. Anyway, the Agency doesn't forget about useful assets, especially when all they need is a few light bulbs and minor remodeling to be made livable."

"Prudent, and cost-efficient," I noted.

"Doesn't matter where you go in the world, governments are always looking to pinch their pennies as hard as possible," Leeroy said. We arrived at the stone bench and took our seats while Arch continued instructing Albert and Sable. I didn't entirely grasp what he was telling them; all I could discern was that he kept moving their arms and legs to slightly different angles than where they'd been. My best guess was that this was some sort of stance advice, though I confess that even that assumption was predicated on watching a cornucopia of action movies.

"This will be interesting." Leeroy was watching the same spectacle I was, but he didn't seem nearly as befuddled by what was going on. "Not even I've gotten to watch a sparring match between weapons of destiny in a long while. They always put on a good show."

I was going to ask what he meant, but before the words could form in my

mouth, Arch had backed up and the match had commenced. After that moment, the question was no longer necessary. I understood exactly what made their tussle interesting.

## 5.

Neither Albert nor Sable were attempting to injure the other. Their movements were slow and deliberate. This seemed to be about control more than anything else, as their respective weapons would draw near to the other's flesh without ever touching it. The sword and axe did clash, however, as each used their respective tool to block the incoming strikes. It was those moments that made this different from any battle I'd ever seen, in cinema or reality.

When the blades of two weapons of destiny collided, they sent ripples out through the world. I realize that sounds as though I'm saying there were flashes of light and waves of sound, which there were, but please understand that there was also something more. At every clash, the very world around them seemed to warp and distort. It was for less than a second, and if not for my vampire eyes, I doubt I would have even seen it. Yet it was undeniably there. Like stones across a lake, these two weapons would ripple through everything around them as they made contact.

"As much as I would like to trust Arch not to put anyone in danger . . . is that safe?"

"Safe is a relative term in our world," Leeroy replied. "If you mean, 'are they guaranteed that nothing will go wrong,' then the answer is no. One of them could slip and lop the other's head off, or they could cause a tear that turns them into slugs. Neither is likely, mind you, just possible. But if you mean, 'is this safer than them never having the experience until they fight an unfriendly weapon and get caught off guard,' then I'd have to say yes. Education is always safer than ignorance."

He had me there, although I did scoot further back in my seat at the word "slug." We sat in silence for some while after that, watching his deputy and my assistant trade blows, halted occasionally by Arch scurrying in and moving someone's foot or elbow. It was strange to see Albert wielding a



blade, all the more so because he actually seemed competent with it. If there was anyone less inclined to violence in the world than me, it was Albert. His avoidance wasn't from cowardice, however. The young man just genuinely seemed too soft-hearted to hurt anyone. I'd only seen him swing that sword one time with intent, and it was when Neil's life was on the line.

"Krystal tells me you two might be hunting for a house around here soon." I started at the voice, having grown so engrossed in the fight that I forgot Leeroy was sitting next to me. His eyes had turned away from the match. Now, they were taking me in with careful observation, which made my slight jump all the more embarrassing.

"It's in discussion," I told him. "She clearly loves it here, and my current home may not be as safe as it once was. Plus, your town does seem quite idyllic."

"Don't let her rose-colored glasses fool you. We get our share of problems same as anyone else," Leeroy replied. "The Agency likes to dump the more problematic potential recruits here for training. Sometimes it works out fine, like with Krystal and Nax, but not every parahuman with power and attitude problems ends up on the straight and narrow. I've got two deputies for a reason."

"Still seems safer than a town where hostile, territorial vampires are moving in." I hadn't actually intended to spill my problems to the sheriff, but if Krystal had told him that we might be moving, it seemed a fair bet she'd also let him know why. Since he didn't seem at all surprised by my statement, my hunch appeared to be right on the money.

"That does look a little worrying," Leeroy agreed. "But let me ask you this, Fred. As a businessman, if you were to move to Boarback, what is one of the very first things you'd do?"

While there was a laundry list of answers to that question, it was clear Leeroy was angling for something specific. I took my time, thinking through every step in moving my business, and almost immediately, I realized what he was trying to say. "I'd look into any other accounting firms in Boarback."

"Because you were planning to kill them?" Leeroy squinted at me in a way that only police seem to be capable of, like they're joking, but don't want to let on that they're joking in case you're willing to accidentally incriminate yourself. If you've ever been pulled over for speeding, then you know the exact look I'm talking about.

"Of course not. Because they would be my competition, and the more I understand about them, the better prepared I'll be. I'd need to know what services they offer, and more importantly, what they don't offer, as well as what failings they have that might entice their customers to look my way. It's the basics of business." His point was obvious; however, there was one glaring flaw in the comparison. "I don't think these vampires are trying to

start their own accounting firms, though.”

“No, they’re trying to move into a territory with a strong therian presence, an ancient dragon, two agents, and a fellow vampire who’s allegedly made alliances with all those powerful people. That sound like a hospitable place to you? It’s a big country, you know. Plenty of spots with easier pickings. Why do you think these vampires are coming to your town, fully aware that they’ll be under the scrutiny of much more dangerous beings?” Leeroy turned back to the watch the fight; evidently, he didn’t expect me to come up with an answer anytime soon.

“Because it’s safe.” I caught a bit of surprise in his eyes as Leeroy glanced at me, but kept on going. Now that the pieces were starting to line up in my head, I couldn’t keep them from tumbling out. “Yes, Winslow is very dangerous if you’re the sort of parahuman who breaks the law, but the flip side is that all those therians, and agents, and Gideon mean that if you keep to the treaties, then you don’t have a lot to fear. A few months ago, a therian tribe tried to overthrow Richard, and they were crushed in a single night.” Actually, they’d been wiped out completely, but I preferred not to think about that part. Not that I, or anyone else, could have saved them. They attacked the King of the West directly, and no one stops Gideon when he’s moved to anger.

“A tribe tried to take over Richard’s spot, huh? Because they just wanted it so bad?”

“No, they were driven . . . out . . . of their home.” I’d forgotten about that detail, amidst all the kidnappings and overthrow attempts. “Are you saying these vampires are refugees fleeing from something?”

Leeroy leaned back, pressing his bulk against the stone wall. “I’m saying there are a lot of ways for a territory to get taken. Maybe you cut off a food source, or drive the locals into a frenzy, or compromise people’s safety at home. And if you’re smart, you can do it just legal enough to keep the law off you, be they agents or cops. Wouldn’t be the first time one group of parahumans has tried to expand their holdings by pushing all the others out. Course, shit like that won’t fly in a well-organized town like the one watched over by Gideon. Dragons are damn fine negotiators; the rules they play by are different than everyone else’s. He doesn’t need to wait for the law.”

It made sense, looking at it from that angle. But there was still one glaring flaw in the hypothesis that I couldn’t get past. “Krystal would know about that, if it were the case. She wouldn’t feel the need to worry about me.”

“Because every fear is always rooted in rational thought and logic?” Leeroy lifted an eyebrow at me and shook his head. “Krystal Jenkins is a good person, a tough lady, and one of the better agents I’ve gotten to train in a long time. That said, she is absolutely terrified of losing people once she lets them in. Can’t blame her, given her history, but it clouds her judgment sometimes. I’m not going to say these vampires have pure-hearted intentions;

they might very well want to put you under the boot or leave your head out to meet the sun. But then again, they may just be trying to make sure you won't have them all slaughtered by your therian friends for stepping on your turf."

"I highly doubt Richard would kill a clan of vampires for me, no matter how much I saved him on his taxes," I said.

"But *they* don't know that," Leeroy countered. "All they know is that this is a town with a lot of powerful people, and some vampire is allegedly connected to most of them. It would be bad business for them not to try and figure out who that is before they get in too deep. Whether it's to kill him or ask him for help is up for discussion; either way, asking about every vampire they know of is the prudent move."

"Well, this certainly made the situation more complicated." I let my head fall back, feeling the impact against the hard stone even though there was no accompanying sense of pain. "I expected you to try and sell me on moving here, since it's what Krystal wants."

"Don't get me wrong, Boarback could use someone with your skills to help audit the books, and I'm sure you'd save my citizens a pretty penny come tax time. Not to mention, I'd love to have Krystal around again. But there's a reason she didn't settle down here before. The lady likes chaos, even on her downtime, and we've only got that in spurts around here. If she comes back, I'd rather it be because she's reached a point where this is the right town for her."

A loud clang filled the air, dragging our attention to the sparring match. Albert was on a knee with his sword held high, Sable's axe pressed against it. Apparently, he'd just stopped a strong blow, as evidenced both by their position on the ground and the fact that a small portion of the rock around them had suddenly turned to glass. Arch let out a whistle and they backed away from each other, seeming to notice for the first time the effect their attack had had on their surroundings.

"If you don't mind me asking, what would you do in my shoes?" I realized that Leeroy and I were in totally different leagues as far as our power went—just shaking his hand had driven that message home loud and clear—but he'd shown an adept mind and offered good perspective, so I was genuinely curious to get his opinion.

"Guess it depends," he said. "The old me would just crush them before they even got a foothold, kill off all the leaders and put the rest to work under my rule. New me would probably just let them be until they stepped out of line, at which point, I'd try to make an example of a few and hope the rest took the message. You're not me, though, even aside from the undead thing. You've got to figure out what the right move for you is."

It was sound, true advice, and I was about to thank Leeroy for it when he continued.

“I will say this, though: running away is almost always an option. It doesn’t vanish the moment you decide to stick around for a little while longer. There’s no shame in retreating from a bigger, stronger threat, but only you know if you’ll be okay with running from just the idea of danger.” Leeroy hefted himself off the bench then, and began to clap as he walked over to Albert and Sable. I didn’t know what he would say to them—probably encouragement, since Arch had combat advice on lockdown.

As for me, I stayed put, the sheriff’s words echoing through my head. I’d never had any issue with fleeing, as a human or a vampire. But he was right; there was a big difference in running away from a real, tangible threat, and just bolting from the possibility of danger. Whichever one I did, I needed to be sure about my choice, because being undead meant that I would have to live with it for a very long time.

## 6.

After a few hours of training, Sable headed back to the station and Leeroy led us through the underground tunnels to another set of stairs, this one emerging inside the Bristle Inn. By then, the others were awake, and we began touring the various shops accessible through the interwoven tunnel system. I had no idea how Leeroy, or the occasional other parahumans we encountered below the surface, navigated such a winding structure. Evidently they did, though, as we would take turn after turn, seemingly doubling back on ourselves, yet always arriving at the exact destination we'd set out for. The tunnels were nearly deserted, as going above ground was far more convenient unless one suffered a sunlight allergy, but the shops were always filled with at least a few patrons. Given the wares they had, I could hardly blame them, as each store was fascinating just to window-shop through.

Neil purchased a few crystals and a bag of powder from a one-eyed woman in a store full of books, scales, and bowls of ingredients that I couldn't identify. They were labeled, but it was a language I wasn't familiar with. In fact, Neil seemed to be the only one among us who could tell what was what, which led me to suspect that perhaps the signs were more magical than linguistic.

At a store with homemade flasks and barrels, I picked up a bottle of Boarback Merlot, along with a six-pack of local mead for Bubba. Krystal also bought some beers, though we'd barely made it out of the store before she cracked one open and guzzled it halfway down. I wasn't sure what the law was as far as open containers went, but seeing as we were walking with the sheriff, it seemed to be okay. Along with the wine and beer, I'd also picked up a new faux-silver flask, this one boasting exceptional thermal insulation and an equally exceptional storage capacity. The clerk made a lot of claims, at least some of which I hoped were true. There were few things worse than

room-temperature blood.

Albert picked up a pair of wrist guards at Arch's suggestion—one of the more harmless purchases possible at a store full of armor and weaponry. It was disconcerting to walk into, actually, nestled as it was amidst the small-town craft stores. This one looked like it would be more at home in a renaissance fair, except that the weaponry there is dull and not suited for real battle. And before you wonder, no, I do not want to go into why I happen to have that knowledge.

No one else seemed bothered by the existence of an armory in the middle of town, so I just chalked it up to “one of those parahuman things” and busied myself examining shields while Albert found a set of wrist guards that fit his arms properly. Thankfully, they didn't take too long, or else I might have ended up buying one of the bucklers to hang over my mantle. Purely for the aesthetic, of course.

We spent the rest of the day browsing the shops, picking up knick-knacks and gifts for those back home. As we made our way through town, I kept my word to Krystal, surveying everything with a critical eye. If we made the move, these would be my only shopping options, and as much fun as they were to visit, I had to try and wrap my mind around not being able to buy anything from outside them. I also kept an eye on the stores we saw through the enchanted windows, making note of the services Boarback offered. There were plenty to be found, but no matter how much I looked, I didn't see so much as even a flyer for any accounting practices in the area. Whether that was good or bad, I still hadn't quite yet determined.

In the evening, Sable and Albert went down for more sparring, with Neil tagging along behind Arch this time. Krystal and I borrowed Leeroy's truck to take a drive into the nearby hills, eventually switching to foot and hiking our way up to a large lake that rested at the top of a steep path. There were no signs or boats to be seen; only a lone gazebo with a golden bell that Krystal informed me I was not to ring under any circumstances. Her promise of the lake's reflectivity had been spot on, as I could see the quarter moon hanging in the sky just by glancing at the smooth surface.

“I wouldn't have expected a place like this when we landed,” I said, transfixed by how undisturbed this natural body of water was. It was unsettling somehow. All the more because I realized the reflectivity meant I couldn't see what dwelled below the surface. Beautiful and still wasn't the same as peaceful; I'd learned that lesson long ago.

“There are plenty more like it.” Krystal leaned over, pressing her head to my shoulder like a cat trying to scratch its ear. “Boarback is bigger than just the town central. Lots of places and parahumans you'd never get a chance to see in the outside world. Most of them friendly, too, or at least not outright hostile. Pretty much the same thing.”

“You love this town quite a bit. If I can ask, why didn’t you settle here? It’s obvious that you get to pick where you call home between missions, and seeing how fond you are of Boarback, I’m shocked you didn’t build a life here.” Perhaps it was overstepping my bounds somewhat to ask such a question, but given what Krystal had asked of me, I felt the question was warranted. Something had kept her from this town before, and if we were considering making the move, then I wanted to know what it was, and why it was no longer an issue. *If* it was no longer an issue.

“Lots of reasons,” she said, not even flinching at the query. “Travel, for one. I don’t hate that plane as much as you, but I don’t want to fly on it that often, and it’s the fastest way in and out of here. Timing was also a factor. The missions I was getting back then were almost all time sensitive, so being somewhere central made it easier to respond. But the sad truth of the matter is that those were just things I used to convince myself that it was the right call. The real reason I didn’t come back was my fiancé, Tem. When training ended, we’d already become an item, so I decided to settle down where he was and see how things played out.”

As we were currently cuddling in front of a romantic lake, I knew quite well how that relationship had turned out, though I was fuzzy on the details of how and why. Krystal rarely talked about her ex-fiancé; in fact, this very well might have been the first time I’d ever heard his name. It certainly seemed like one that would have stuck in my memory. The experience had been a painful one for her, so I didn’t press the issue. What had come before didn’t matter to me; I only cared for our future.

“Once that went to shit, I threw myself into my work. There were stretches where I didn’t see my apartment for months on end. I just stopped caring where I hung my hat, and even after I eased off the gas at the Agency, where I lived didn’t matter much. Not until I had people worth coming back to, anyway.”

I’d always wondered why it was so easy for her to move to Winslow from wherever she’d been before, but the reasoning made sense. Even aside from our budding relationship, she’d had Albert to watch over, and then her old friend Bubba to visit with. Since then, the number of reasons to come home had only grown. And if we moved to Boarback, we’d lose almost all of them.

“Krystal, this town is beautiful, and I’m still struck with wonder at the idea of getting to live openly as a vampire instead of worrying every day about being discovered. We could be content here, I think.” Her head rose from my shoulder, affection evident in her eyes; however, I leaned back before she could make contact. I needed to finish this, while I still had the courage to do so.

“But I’m not okay with content. I would have been, a few years ago. If you’d promised me a town where I could be safe and have a reliable income

stream, I'd have jumped at it, no questions asked. Things have changed, though. As appealing as contentment is, the price is simply too high. Being with you, having all our friends, it makes me happy. Happier than I ever thought I could be. That's not something I'm inclined to give up easily. Maybe if this threat becomes real, if we learn the new vampires definitely want me out of the picture, then it will be a different story. I just can't run yet. Winslow, and more importantly the people in it, are my home. I don't want to lose that unless it's absolutely necessary."

"This from the guy who ran away from a few werewolves at a high school reunion," Krystal said.

"To be fair, they were also total assholes," I replied. "Werewolves or no."

"That they were." She leaned in closer to me, and I didn't pull back this time. My piece was said. How she chose to respond was up to her. "I had a feeling it wouldn't be that easy of a sell. You're more willful than you think you are. We can go back and see where things lead, as long as you're willing to promise me one thing. If it comes time to run, you *run*."

"I can assure you that will not be a problem in the slightest," I told her.

"Yeah, you say that, but sometimes . . . never mind. Let's just enjoy the vacation while we can."

The gap between our faces disappeared as she leaned in, kissing me with more fury and need than her usual playful affection. It is neither possible nor prudent to say how long we stayed like that; I will simply say that when we parted, we turned our eyes skyward to the true moon and stars rather than their watery reflections.

"Fred," Krystal whispered, possibly in the softest tone I'd ever heard from her.

"Yes?"

"If you die on me, I'm going to kick the shit out of you. Fair warning."

I pulled her closer and ran my pale hand through her golden hair. "I am suitably intimidated, and will do my best to avoid the ass-kicking."

"See, that's why I like the smart ones. They know how to take a good threat."

We lay under the stars for several more hours before finally making our way back down the trail and driving to town. It was the most serene evening we'd had in a long time, even if unknown danger did lurk beneath the surface.



## 7.

After another day of shopping, delectable food from the diner, and training for Albert, Neil, and Sable, the time had come to head back out to the field and catch our plane home. Packing our bags was a quick affair, and after a brief hike from the Bristle Inn to the police station, we piled back into the sheriff's truck to head out. This time, however, Nax and Sable were coming along to see us off, so that put two of us riding in the truck's bed. I was almost entirely certain that such an act was technically illegal, but given everyone's respective hardiness, it didn't make sense to fret about being thrown from the rear.

To no one's surprise, Arch immediately volunteered to take a position in the bed, hand already on the cigarettes in his pocket. But before he could move, Sheriff Leeroy had grabbed me by the shoulder and started moving us both to the back.

"None of that, Arch. You've only got a little time left with my deputy. I want you imparting every bit of knowledge that you can before the plane arrives. Fred and I will ride in the bed." Leeroy caught the annoyed, frustrated look on Arch's face and met it with a wide grin. "Unless you'd like to tussle for it. I've told you before, I'm always up for a rematch."

There was a long moment where I genuinely thought Arch and Leeroy were going to have a sparring match over who had to ride on the hard, bouncy surface of a beat-up truck bed. After a lengthy stare, however, Arch slowly made his way back to the front of the vehicle, pausing before entering to throw one last line Leeroy's way.

"The next time we fight, it will be when I *know* I am going to beat you."

"Looking forward to it!" There was so much enthusiasm in Leeroy's voice that what was almost certainly a taunt came off sounding sincere. I still didn't know what Leeroy was—or Arch, for that matter—but I did know Arch's

reputation according to Krystal, and he was considered one of the Agency's top people. For Leeroy to have beaten him, well, let's just say that the sheriff of Boarback was apparently packing more than just an aura of power.

I leapt into the back—literally, in my case—while Leeroy pulled himself up through the tailgate. His large hands smacked the side of the truck twice, and Nax started it up, pulling out of the driveway and onto Sunshine Lane.

Due to the speed with which everything had happened, and the interaction with Arch, it wasn't until we were driving away from town that I realized Leeroy had purposely pulled me away from the group so that it was just the two of us. Otherwise, he'd have just let Arch take the other side of the truck bed. Sure enough, Leeroy was watching me, his cheerful eyes peering out from under his beige hat. I waited for him to say something, to start the conversation, but the seconds ticked by into minutes and there was only silence. Finally, my own nerves got the best of me and I blurted out the first thing that came to mind.

"Am I about to get the 'don't hurt her' speech?"

"Beg pardon?" He tilted his head back a couple of inches, removing the hat's shadow from his face.

"You know, the speech where you tell me that I should make sure not to hurt Krystal, or you'll hurt me. It's a cliché classic, and when you pulled me back here, I sort of assumed . . . ." My voice trailed off as Leeroy began to loudly chuckle, small waves of laughter washing over him.

"Fred, I don't need to tell you not to hurt Krystal. For one thing, it's plain as day that you two are in love. And that means you're going to hurt each other; it's unavoidable. You'll make mistakes, say the wrong thing, pick the wrong action, and her feelings will get hurt. Same thing she'll do to you. The ones we love can hurt us the most easily, but we can also forgive them just as freely. Long as the hurt stays unintentional, I think you two will be fine for a while yet."

His laughter finally subsided, and he looked out at the woods the truck was winding through on a narrow path. "Besides, if you ever screwed up really bad, what could I do to you that's worse than what Krystal would? By now, you've probably figured out that she doesn't need anyone to fight her battles for her, especially not an old sheriff half a country away."

"I suppose you have me there," I admitted. "Then, what did you want to talk about?"

"Who said I wanted to talk about anything?" Leeroy replied.

"You pulled me into the back of the truck, and didn't let Arch take my place. I assumed there was a reason for that."

Leeroy nodded. "There was. I like riding in the back, and I'm not a fan of cigarette smoke. Ruins the scent of the outdoors. Arch is a good agent, but that habit of his drives me nuts. You don't smoke, and you seemed pleasant

enough, so I decided to drag you along to keep him from joining. Sometimes a ride in a truck is just that.”

If that wasn’t a cue to shut up and enjoy the ride, I didn’t know what was, so I let the subject drop and looked out at the trees. The path we were driving on was so small that the vehicle barely fit. Branches stuck out from both sides, coming within inches of scratching me. Leeroy, with his wider frame, got smacked occasionally, though he didn’t seem bothered by it. I wasn’t entirely sure he even noticed. As the trees struck, he simply sat there with the same placid expression he’d been wearing since we met. I’d met several parahumans who were considered to be incredibly powerful, but none of them had been as relaxed and cheery as Sheriff Thorgood. In an odd way, that made me even more afraid of him than the others.

“You do remote work?” Leeroy’s voice stood out like a horn in the hypnotic rhythm of the truck’s engine. It caught me so off guard that I took a few moments to process the question, and several more to work out what exactly he was asking.

“Depends,” I told him. “I’ve learned that most parahumans keep paper records, so I have to be on-site to process those. If they’ve gone digital, then it’s another story. Those jobs, I can do anywhere. At a cheaper rate, too, since it doesn’t take me nearly as long.”

“Yeah, we’re still on paper,” Leeroy admitted. “Krystal says your company does a good job, though. Might be worth it to fly one of you out here come April. Dealing with the city finances is my least favorite part of this job.”

“Wouldn’t that be a job for the town mayor, or treasurer?” Even as I spoke, I realized that I’d never actually seen a city hall anywhere in Boarback, nor had there been any mention of a governmental system. It was just the sheriff and his deputies.

“It’s all on my plate,” Leeroy said, confirming my suspicion. “You make something, be it a kid or a town, it’s on you to look after it.”

“Wait, are you saying you founded Boarback?” It was more surprising than shocking. After all, the town couldn’t be more than a few centuries old, and there were certainly parahumans that measured their lives in millennia. With how powerful Leeroy seemed, it made sense that he’d been around for a long while. I just hadn’t expected the town’s founder to still be working as its sheriff.

“Seems like yesterday,” he told me. “Except for the paperwork. I’d swear I’ve done lifetimes’ worth of that. Makes me miss the old days, before there were so many forms and boxes. Someone showed up with a bill, and you either paid it or drove them off. Of course, that was before I held a respectable office, like sheriff.”

Despite not completely understanding what he was talking about, I did my

best to conjure a sympathetic nod. “April is a tight time for me, and all other accountants, but since you’re a friend of Krystal’s, I can carve out a few days to come lend a hand.”

Leeroy waved me off. “We don’t need the boss down here; things aren’t that tough. One of your people will be fine.”

“The company is just me and Albert, and he isn’t properly trained to do a full accounting service on his own.”

“Oh.” For the first time, Leeroy looked a touch surprised. It didn’t last long, though. In seconds, he’d faded back to the warm, relaxed grin that was usually there. “Well then, sure, we’d gladly accept your help. I can even pay some in advance.”

I began to protest that it wasn’t necessary, but before I’d gotten more than a few syllables out, Leeroy had produced a small glass vial. Inside were a few drops of red liquid that my base instincts immediately recognized as blood. There was something off about it, though. A curious rainbow sheen seemed to shimmer on the edges, like gasoline spilled on a lake. He tossed it to me and I caught it on reflex, my arm moving without even bothering to check with my brain.

“Had a feeling that would come in handy,” he said. “Takes a hell of a lot to make me bleed, not even I can manage it without a proper weapon, but a few decades back, there was a rough dragon that tried to settle down in the hills. Sucker managed to get a few drops from me, so I put them away for a rainy day.”

“This is your blood?” Even through the glass, I could smell what was inside. It smelled delicious, and savory, and *strong*. Much as I loathe to admit it, my mouth had begun to salivate, acting completely on its own, with no regard for propriety.

“Sure is. Few drops will give you quite the pick-me-up. Might come in handy if those new vampires decide to cause trouble.” There was something in Leeroy’s eyes that I couldn’t quite place. Not aggression, and not judgment. Curiosity? Regardless, the vial had most of my attention. The few drops inside were so powerful I could feel them before they even hit my tongue. If I drank it, would I be safe? It was hard to imagine any other vampire being a threat, not unless they were feeding off a dragon.

With a last long, lingering look at the blood, I tossed it back to Leeroy, who easily snatched it from the air. “Thank you, but Fletcher Accounting Services only accepts payment by check, credit card, or direct deposit, and we don’t take advances for services not yet rendered.”

Slowly, he put the blood back in his shirt pocket, eyes never leaving me. “You have any idea what you just threw away?”

“Power, strength, the ability to live without fear of any who might do me harm. Like I said, thank you, but no, thank you. I got a taste of that last year

when an ancient dragon gave me his blood. It was more inconvenience than anything. I'm fine with what I've got. Maybe it falls short for a conquering vampire, but for an accountant, it's more than enough." My fingers were still tingling from where I'd been holding the vial, though the feeling was finally fading.

The truck made a few more turns and had just burst into the clearing when Leeroy spoke again. The cheer had faded from his voice, and something else was there in its place. Experience, wisdom, some indefinable quality that only one who has lived far beyond mortal years is able to conjure.

"I've seen many things, long as I've been alive. The rise and fall of countries, the very earth shift beneath our feet, the birth and death of waves of human generations, gone so quickly it's like the flash of a firefly. Yet, in all that time, I've only encountered a handful of people, human or para, who had what it took to turn down power when it was before them. I think I might see what Krystal loves in you, Fredrick Fletcher."

Something shivered down my spine as he said my name, but by the time the willies had passed, so too had Leeroy's shift in mood. He was smiling again as the truck began to slow, our plane already in sight.

"Don't you go dying on me before April, now. If I have to deal with all those finances myself, I am going to be quite annoyed. Push comes to shove, I'll even lend a hand to keep you alive if needed. Just make sure it's really necessary. Like one of my favorite humans said: 'If you must hit, do not hit softly.' I don't pull my punches."

I nodded my understanding as the truck finally came to a stop and everyone began to hop out. All of a sudden, the vampires waiting back in Winslow didn't seem quite so scary; at least, not when compared to the man who watched over the town of Boarback. The weight of his offer slowed me even as we loaded our bags back into the plane's small cargo hold. Did he mean that I could call him in if things got too dangerous? This wasn't a quick trip. How would he get there in time? And if he did come, how much of Winslow would be left standing when he was finished?

Goodbyes were said, and hands were shaken. Albert and Sable exchanged e-mail addresses, while Neil stood awkwardly nearby. Leeroy pulled Krystal in for a long hug before finally releasing her, then slapped Arch heartily on the back as he snuck in one pre-flight smoke. Nax also gave Krystal an embrace, though his was more tentative than the bear hug Sheriff Thorgood had used.

Eventually, all the pleasantries were exchanged and we boarded the plane. Neil took a window seat, downed a glowing green potion he'd mixed up in a water bottle, and promptly passed out. I wasn't sure if he'd tried to make something to suppress nausea or to force him into sleep, but either way, given who Neil's instructor was, I knew that what he'd taken was bound to be

potent. And possibly illegal, though I never quite understood where alchemical potions fell in terms of drug use. Albert took the seat next to Neil, three air-sick bags already in hand, just in case, and Arch sat down across the aisle from his pupil. They'd probably spend the flight reviewing Albert's matches with Sable and which techniques to polish, none of which interested me in the slightest. Listening to Arch talk about fighting made me understand how most people felt when I tried to explain the difference between an IRA and a Roth IRA.

I ended up with a window seat as well, since Krystal liked to stretch her legs into the aisle while she napped. This afforded me a view of Boarback as the plane began its wobbling rise upward. We started out so low that I could see the sheriff's truck's headlights in flashes as they moved through the woods. Further out, the lights of Boarback's town center glowed, a small oasis of light in a sea of dark trees. It looked peaceful, even from so far up. Maybe, one day, I would come back to this place for more than an accounting job. Maybe Krystal and I would move here when things were too dangerous, or we just wanted a more peaceful daily life.

This was not that day, though. As the plane rose higher and Boarback faded from sight, I felt an unexpected sense of relief in my stomach. Even after only a few days away, I'd gotten homesick for Winslow, Colorado, and the people who lived there. It had been a nice vacation, but I was glad that it was coming to an end.

Waiting vampire clans be damned, it was time for us to go home.

# A Lawyer in the Mansion

## 1.

Despite the worry with which we returned to Winslow, relatively little happened in the weeks to follow. My home was released, having been officially cleaned and cleared of all the traps Colin, the rogue hunter, had left behind. I was also relatively certain that roughly half the beers I kept in my fridge for guests had vanished as well, but since Krystal was the largest consumer of those, that was her battle to fight. Apparently, none of the Agency's trap-detectors had much of a taste for red wine.

For the first few days, every time my new phone rang, I was sure it would be Krystal calling to let me know that more inquires had come down and she thought I was in danger. Eventually, though, the fear subsided, and I fell back into my regular routine. This process was helped along by the fact that I was positively swamped, fighting my way back to being on schedule after the short trip to Boarback. I even had to ask Albert to skip a few lessons, so great was my need for assistance. In the hectic rush of working overtime to hit my deadlines with every client, there was little room in my mind for the more abstract fears, like what a new vampire clan in town was up to.

Perhaps that was why I didn't bristle with suspicion when Amy and Bubba showed up at my apartment one evening, announcing themselves with a quick phone call five minutes prior to let me know they were on their way. My instincts finally whispered that something might be up when Amy walked through the door holding a fine bottle of pinot noir, with the cork still intact. While Amy Wells was a good friend and a talented mage, she wasn't the type to bring a bottle of wine just for a drop-in, and if she did, then she would almost always try to . . . augment it with some of her concoctions.

"This looks lovely," I told her, accepting the bottle because, suspicious or

not, there are certain rules one is supposed to observe when playing host. “May I ask what the occasion is?”

“We need a favor.” Bubba, at least, was a man I could always count on to cut to the quick of things. Towering over both me and Amy, he wore his usual arrangement of flannel, denim, and a beat-up trucker’s hat. Compared to an alpha therian like Richard, Bubba wasn’t much, but outside of that anomalous group, he was easily one of the biggest people I’d ever met. Also one of the most loyal and kindest, which was perhaps why Richard had been tasking Bubba with more and more assignments in recent months. Loyalty was worth its weight in gold, even in the parahuman world.

“Way to ease him in,” Amy muttered, tossing an elbow to his ribs that I doubt he even registered. “But yeah, Bubba’s right. We need a favor. Well, actually, I need it. Well, actually, some friends of mine need it. Well, actually —”

“If possible, can we jump ahead to the details?” I asked. Amy had small green orbs rotating around her irises, which meant she, as usual, had tried one of her own potions. Without knowing how this one impacted her mind and thought pattern, it was best to try and corral the conversation toward productive ends.

“A mage died last week,” Bubba said. “Herbram Clover.”

“Oh, I’m sorry for your loss. Was he a friend?” I asked Amy.

“Met him a few times at the swap meets for spell-casters. Decent guy, but after a few beers, he could talk the ears off a sphynx.” Amy didn’t seem particularly broken up about it, though whether that was due to her own feelings or the magical concoction coursing through her blood was anyone’s guess.

“Herbram did some work for Richard at times, along with a lot of other folks. He was a talented enchanter, very respected, very pricey.” Bubba walked over to my fridge and pulled out one of the recently restocked silver beer cans. At this point, everyone knew they were there for guests, so there was little need for formality. “Thing is, he had two children, Ainsley and Zane. He also left behind a damned hefty estate, and he actually drafted somethin’ of a will.”

“The problem is that he didn’t get nearly specific enough,” Amy added. “All he said was that the estate was to be split evenly between his children. That’s it; that was the whole will.”

A year prior, I might not have grasped what she was saying, but after becoming a Certified Public Parahuman Accountant and working with all my new clients, I’d learned a great deal about how parahumans regarded paperwork. Turns out that, much like regular humans, they despised it. And since they had so many ways to avoid it, very little was ever actually done. Putting all that together, I could instantly see the issue with Herbram Clover’s



estate.

“He never had any of it appraised or insured, did he? It was just a note saying to split things evenly, trusting his children to work the rest out themselves.” I knew I’d hit the nail on the head by the long draw Bubba took from his beer.

“Right between the eyes,” Bubba replied. “It’s been a fine mess ever since. They’re bickerin’ over who gets what, what’s worth what, and meanwhile, Herbram’s business is falling apart.”

Amy took a seat at my dining room table, although I noticed the chair seemed to move when she reached for it, rather than when contact was made. “Herbram was a friend of Richard’s, and I’ve worked with Ainsley a few times, so we got them to agree to use a lawyer who would settle the matter fairly. Problem is, she doesn’t have the numbers background to properly work through Herbram’s books, and said it would take weeks longer unless we got an accountant. Well, actually, she said it would take an extra four weeks. Well —”

“Got it. Estate in trouble, accountant needed, and I’m one of the few in town who actually knows how to do parahuman books.” My mind raced as I tried to do some hurried guesswork. The fact that Herbram had kept books and made a will were both quite promising facts. They’d be terrible, of course—I’d yet to meet a single parahuman aside from myself who kept fastidious records—but it was still more than I was accustomed to starting with. With a lawyer to help and a confined estate to work with, there was a good chance I could get the job done in only a few days. It would be a tight squeeze, schedule-wise, but I couldn’t turn down a request from friends. Especially Richard, who I suspected might be the only reason there had yet to be any unfamiliar vampires knocking on my door.

“If I pull a lot of overtime this weekend, I should be able to clear some space out for early next week. Assuming things are remotely in order, I’d require roughly three to six days,” I told them. “However, you’ll need to take on the job of explaining to Krystal why I’m canceling our weekend plans. That task is non-negotiable.”

I’d expected some sort of relief or happiness at my willingness to help. Instead, Bubba and Amy exchanged a long glance between themselves. While not the most astute reader of body language in the world, even I could tell that meant something was wrong.

“What? Is six days too long? If the books are somewhat in order, I might be able to do it faster, but I can’t make any promises yet.”

“No, that’s not the problem. Well, actually, it is, since they need it done soon. Well, actually, we need it done soon. Well—”

This time, it was Bubba who cut Amy off, which I was grateful for. “Ainsley and Zane ain’t exactly the most chummy of siblings. Things are

gettin' heated the longer it goes on, and when mages get heated, that can cause trouble all around."

"I see. So, how soon were you hoping I'd be able to get started?"

Bubba's eyes darted down to the half-cracked watch on his wrist, which told me all I needed to know before he even spoke. "The lawyer was hopin' to meet us in about an hour."

"An hour?" While I'd technically finished all my work for the day, having stayed at my computer through the sunlight hours to keep at it, that didn't mean I relished the idea of zipping off into the night for a sudden job. There were still things that needed doing, and if the job took half as long as I was expecting, it would cause me to miss deadlines, something I considered an unforgivable sin for a fledgling business. "Look, you know I'm always happy to help out, but this is just too little notice. I can't abandon everything else at the drop of a hat."

"Lawyer said you might feel that way, so she got the Clover children to authorize an extra fee on top of what you usually charge, for the short notice," Bubba said.

"I can't imagine there's a number that would justify me tossing my entire schedule out the window for one unexpected client."

That sentiment lasted exactly as long as it took for Bubba to tell me the number.

"Then again, I suppose it couldn't hurt to at least take a look at the books," I said, backpedaling quickly. It wasn't greed that motivated me so much as pragmatism. With a sudden income influx that high, I might be able to lure in some other parahuman as an employee, whether they liked the work or not. Besides, I could always forgo my daily sleep for another week or so to rebuild the lost time. I didn't usually get loopy until it had been at least ten days without nodding off. Seriously loopy, anyway.

"Great, I'll drive," Amy said. A jolt of fear raced through me, but Bubba shook his head before she'd even gotten out of her chair.

"We took my truck, remember? I'll drive. Fred, get whatever you need." Bubba finished off his beer and tossed the can in the recycling. He didn't go the fridge for another, which I appreciated. Therian constitution or not, I preferred my guests limit their drinking to one an hour if they were getting behind the wheel. Given that he could probably polish off a keg on his own and not pass out, Bubba was a surprisingly good sport about it, and Amy always preferred her own work anyway. In fact, the resistance most parahumans had to mortal vices like alcohol was what fueled her business. Those who wanted a buzz needed something stronger, products that only a talented alchemist could provide.

As I stuffed my laptop into the bag already filled with other supplies, hefting my remote scanner under my arm, I heard Amy's voice from the

kitchen. “Maybe we should warn him.”

“Warn me about what?” Despite my reluctance to admit accidental eavesdropping, I’d long ago learned that if there was a warning to be had, then it was something I wanted.

“Nothin’ dangerous,” Bubba said, a hair too quickly. “She just means we should let you know what to expect before we get there.”

“Is this place hidden in a dark forest that’s only accessible through magical means, or something?” I asked.

Bubba shook his head. “Pretty much the opposite. Just try to keep in mind, everybody mourns in their own way.”

## 2.

As it turned out, what Bubba meant was that some people mourned by surrounding themselves with people. While most of us might go the route of having loved ones nearby, evidently Zane Clover was one to prefer quantity over quality. I could see the people milling about on his yard even as we made our way up the long driveway, Bubba's truck an anomaly amidst the more ostentatious luxury vehicles already parked on the side of the drive. The valet booth at the front explained how so many cars were so neatly arranged, and we watched as a sleek black automobile pulled up, a pair of stunning people tossing over their keys without a second thought. If you're wondering how there was room for so many vehicles—and who could blame you?—it turned out that there was a reason Bubba and Amy had referred to the inheritance as an “estate.”

Herbram Clover's mansion was in the Cloudy Meadows community—easily the most expensive, exclusive area of Winslow, Colorado. Just to get in, Bubba had been forced to drive past two guard gates, where they checked his name and ID, along with another guard in front of Herbram's actual driveway. The grounds were sprawling, with large trees separating the property from their neighbors—not that the next house was in earshot, anyway. As for the house, it seemed more akin to a castle than a home, albeit one with modern lighting and a DJ booth set up out on the lawn. At least a hundred people were milling about in front of elegant tables with fine food and expensive liquor that had been set up at careful intervals. White-shirted wait staff made their way around, blending into the background as they cleared off finished plates and made sure drinks never got below half-empty.

“The good news is that if this is the rate they're blowing through the inheritance, I doubt it will take much time at all to figure out how much to split.”

“You'd think that, but the parties are all out of Zane's trust,” Amy said. Since leaving, she'd drunk a test tube of purple liquid that changed the orbs around her irises to long, shapeless blobs. It had also lifted the tone of her voice by several octaves, but since she'd stopped with the “well, actually” stuff, I considered it a more than fair trade.

“Parties? As in, he's done this more than once?” With just a cursory glance, I could see thousands upon thousands of dollars spent in every corner of the lawn. What it cost as a whole boggled the mind, let alone multiplied into multiple events. Part of me wondered if I'd gotten low-balled on the extra fee.

“Done one just about every night since his dad passed.” Bubba pulled behind a bright yellow sports car and killed the truck, popping the door open and tossing his key to the approaching valet. The red-vested man seemed a touch confused by the beat-up truck amidst a sea of luxury, but he didn’t let it stop him from doing his job.

“He took the loss hard,” Amy added.

“So I can see. What exactly did Herbram Clover do, again, that afforded such a lifestyle?”

“Enchanter,” Amy told me. “Brilliant work, passed down through the family for generations. The Clover name is synonymous with power and craftsmanship. And that’s the sort of thing you pay a premium for.”

There was no debating that part, as Amy and Bubba led me into a front hall filled with more staff, offering drinks and to take coats, along with a fresh wave of partiers. All around me, I saw designer labels and surgically perfected faces. The scent of plastic was practically overwhelming, at least for my vampiric nose. We got a few strange looks as Bubba politely cleared a way through the crowd, Amy’s flowing, simple dress and my professional attire likely costing less than anyone’s individual shoe. Thankfully, they did move, as a man Bubba’s size commands an instinctual respect, regardless of how much his clothes are worth.

Finally, we made it to a stairway with only a few partiers drifting about, climbing quickly past a velvet rope with a guard who’d have seemed intimidating if Bubba didn’t have at least half a foot on him. To my surprise, the guard greeted us with a genuine smile, pulling the rope aside and letting us pass as he and Bubba exchanged a few words. My best guess said that he was a fellow therian, as they were renowned for being good muscle, though he didn’t look at me with as much disdain as I’d have expected. Perhaps he was just a muscular human who appreciated dealing with regular folks instead of an endless stream of the wealthy.

After navigating several long hallways, we at last arrived in front of a pair of double doors, blocked by two more guards who nodded at Bubba and Amy on sight. They looked at me suspiciously, but Amy whispered a few words and they stepped aside without comment.

“We got Ainsley to hire the guards after the first few drunks wandered in and bothered the lawyer,” Bubba whispered as one of the guards unlocked the door. “Moved the work to a secure room, too. Used to be Herbram’s study; supposed to be warded six ways to Sunday.”

It occurred to me that I’d never asked for more information about this lawyer of theirs. Everything else had been so overwhelming it was a detail that slipped through the cracks. I was about to inquire when the door opened, and I saw a figure flipping through files, free hand dancing along the nearby notepad as it jotted down the bits deemed worth remembering.

“Asha?”

Sure enough, a familiar face looked up from the notepad, and there was Asha Patel. She looked a little different since I’d last seen her—hair cut shorter, clothes less formal. She also didn’t look half-terrified, most likely because this time, we weren’t trapped in Charlotte Manor under threat of death. In Charlotte’s defense, it had been an issue of self-preservation, and she’d apologized for the incident several times since.

“When they said they knew an accountant, I had a feeling it would be you.” She rose from her seat as I walked in the room, followed by Bubba and Amy. We exchanged a brief hug, more familiar than I’d be with most colleagues, but there’s nothing like a near-death experience to create a bond.

“Well, I had no idea I’d find you here. What happened? Last time we talked, you were heading home to try and drink until the previous few hours were nothing but a blurry memory.” Behind us, the doors shut once again, and I heard the lock being slid back into place.

“Damnedest thing, I was out of wine. Can you believe it?” Asha said. “That, and once I got away, I couldn’t stop thinking about everything you told me, and that I’d seen. I ended up going back to the site with the parahuman law books. I thought if I understood it all, maybe it wouldn’t be so scary.”

A sound idea, and one easily executed. Parahuman laws are hidden in plain sight in the form of a role-playing game. It allows them to be easily accessible by anyone, without humans realizing what they’re actually seeing. Most people think it’s just a very dry, boring game, though I’ve heard there are a few diehard fans scattered about the country.

“It sort of worked,” Asha continued. “After a few hours of reading, I was able to fall asleep. Then I did the same thing the next night, and the next, and eventually, I realized that I was forcing myself to learn. There was this whole other world of law and precedent I’d never seen before, and I wanted to know everything about it. You can probably fill in the details from there.”

“Once you had the knowledge, you wanted to use it, which you couldn’t do at Torvald & Torvald,” I surmised. “So you started freelancing in your off time.”

“Close, but not quite,” Asha replied. “I got a few certifications while still at the company, but once I was cleared to go, I made the jump whole hog. Turned in my resignation and started up my own company. Been going around two months now, and business is booming.”

“Glad to hear it. Though, honestly, I didn’t even know normal people could work with parahumans in such a capacity,” I said.

“It’s not exactly smiled upon, but there’s no law against it.” Amy’s voice came from my left; she had wandered over, running her hands along the files as she did. “While we’re not supposed to go around telling humans that we’re here, a few find out anyway. If someone knows, and they decide to fill a need

in the parahuman market, there's not any real reason to stop them. Long as they exercise discretion and don't go blabbing, it's okay."

"Long story short, I had to fill out so many confidentiality agreements and secrecy clauses that I had a two-day long hand cramp." Asha shook her fingers, as if the ghost of the pain still lingered in her digits. "But I pushed through, and now I'm certified to work with parahumans. Good thing, too. For a culture that has real vampires as a part of it, there are shockingly few lawyers."

"Low blow," I told her.

"My job, I get to make the jokes." She patted the table, drawing my attention the large stack of files and ledgers spread out across it. "I assume Bubba and Amy filled you in on our situation?"

"They understated the scope, but I got the gist of things. Huge inheritance, the only directive is an even split, and our clients can't agree on a fair division. Did I miss anything?"

"Just the most problematic point." Asha sat back down, grabbing a nearby file, and I pulled up a chair next to her. Bubba and Amy also took seats, though they kept well away from where the paperwork was being discussed.

"The liquid assets, cash and gold, were kept mostly in bank accounts and treasure chests," Asha began, running her hand along a line of numbers so large I thought I might actually swoon. "Those, along with the house, were relatively easy to calculate a value for. Same for a lot of the antiques and collectibles. It'll take time, but I can get some appraisers in to assess a value. What's kept this procedure from moving forward is the tools."

"I have a suspicion you don't mean a belt sander," I muttered.

"What I wouldn't give," Asha replied. "No, these are enchanter's tools, passed down along the Clover line for centuries. Part of what makes their products so valuable. Very powerful stuff, or so I'm told. Apparently, it's a complete set, and it can't be split up without reducing the usefulness to a point where they might as well be generics. That's our biggest issue: whichever child gets the tools is essentially being handed the Clover business. The other can trade on the name, but without those tools, the odds of producing the same quality of goods are almost null."

"Interesting. So, in fair division of assets, we have to calculate the value of the tools in terms of potential income for an expected mage's life span, and offset the gain for one client by giving the other an equivalent amount of the other assets." Hesitant as I'd been to come along, I'd be lying if I said the challenge didn't intrigue me. The calculations needed to put everything together were going to be uniquely complex, and that was without planning for the usual hiccups one always encountered in this kind of work.

"They have weird ideas of interesting," I heard Bubba tell Amy from across the table.

“Do either of the children have a better claim to the business than the other?” I asked, ignoring my friend’s words of boredom. “If one lacks the talent to actually keep the business afloat, then that would give the tools a diminished value in their hands.”

Asha shook her head, flipping a few pages ahead to a small summary showing a pair of striking similar people. “Both were educated by their father, and are considered top-notch mages. Ainsley has a bit more technical know-how; some people think she’s already passed her father’s level of skill. Zane is a much better people-person, though; in case the party downstairs didn’t tip you off. He’s been handling a lot of the new client acquisition for several years.”

“I suppose that’s easier then. The tools are equal in value regardless of who gets them.” I looked at the mound of ledgers and papers lying on the table, most of which were of the same style as the one Asha was holding. “Did you do all of this?”

“Transcribed a lot of it; kept the original for some, though,” Asha replied. “I like to keep things organized.”

“On that point, we definitely agree. Do you have the records for what Clover earned off his tools for the past decade or so? I’ll need that as a starting point.”

“Way ahead of you.” Asha grabbed a particularly thick file and plopped it down in front of me as I pulled out my laptop.

“Then let’s get to work.” Looking back, perhaps it would have been more prudent to downplay my excitement, but in that moment, all I could see was the intriguing prospect of the challenge set before me.



### 3.

It's impossible to say how long we'd been working before the doors burst open. I was so absorbed in combing through the numbers that I'd completely lost all sense of time. The only thing that really betrayed the ticking of minutes was Bubba, who'd fallen asleep in his chair and was snoring softly. Amy had downed another potion not long after he nodded off, and every time I glanced at her, she was staring up at the ceiling. Truthfully, I had no idea if she was conscious or not, especially since her reaction to the doors slamming open was a quiet, bird-like *cheep*.

"Enough is enough!" The woman who came striding through, unhindered by either of the bulky guards standing at the door, was quite striking. Emerald robes hung from her body, complementing her dark skin while simultaneously giving her an air of wisdom and mystique. Clutched in her hand was a large wooden staff, intricate symbols carved up and down its length. As I looked at them, I thought I caught a few shifting, ever so slightly slithering about along the staff's surface. Her eyes took the whole room in with a glance, locking on Asha and promptly ignoring the rest of us.

"We brought you here to put an end to this impasse," she declared, crossing the room in several quick-stepped strides. Despite the aura of power she threw off, I realized that she was actually rather diminutive, no more than a couple of inches over five feet tall. "But still the matter remains unsettled, and meanwhile, my brother fills this house with revelry night after night. I just caught sight of someone . . . *relieving* themselves in my herb garden. Do you know what that does to nightshade?"

"Depends on what the person has eaten today," Amy said, her voice so soft and detached that I think I was the only one who heard it. In spite of the commotion, Bubba still snored in his chair. That, at least, wasn't much of surprise. As a former trucker, he'd gotten used to taking rest wherever he could, and it would take more than a little shouting to rouse him.

"Ainsley, please calm down. I promise, we're making progress." Asha motioned for me to come over, so I slowly made my forward, catching Ainsley Clover's attention for the first time. "This is Fredrick Fletcher, of Fletcher Accounting Services. He's here to help me calculate the fair distribution of assets for you and Zane."

Ainsley scrutinized me, slowly moving her eyes up and down, as if she were trying to pick apart every aspect of my being. "A vampire? Are you sure he isn't one of my brother's guests who wandered up from downstairs? I've never known a vampire to be good for more than decadence and

betrayal.”

“With all due respect, Ms. Clover, Asha called me in to help with this case as a favor. If you don’t want me here, then I can take my leave. And if you’re going to continue to make those kinds of comments, I think I’d rather go, regardless.” Ainsley wasn’t the first client I’d met who had certain ideas about vampires, and honestly, it was hard to debate those people on many points. Since vampires could take the abilities of other parahumans by drinking their blood, my species had earned a reputation for feeding by any means necessary. However, that didn’t mean I had to work with people who couldn’t manage basic civility. Swamped as I was, there were plenty of clients out there who could at least mind their manners; I no longer bothered with the ones that lacked that skill.

Asha’s eyes went wide at my words, though I’m not sure if she was afraid for my safety or the fact she’d have to try and find another CPPA on such short notice. Ainsley just kept staring at me for another few seconds, then finally dipped her head.

“Forgive me, Mr. Fletcher. I’ve never been quite adept at interacting with others, and this business with my father’s estate has me out of sorts. You’re right. I’ve no place to judge you by your fangs, and if Asha has brought you in, then I trust that you have the skill to do the job.”

“It’s all right. This happens more than you’d think,” I assured her. “And please, call me Fred. Everyone else already does.”

“Then you may refer to me by my first name, as well.” Ainsley turned from me back to Asha, her tone much calmer than when she’d come bursting in the door. “I appreciate that this is not an easy task, but please tell me that we’re nearing completion. The sooner this is all settled, the sooner I can get back to work. Zane has his parties, but without the tools, all I can do is plan and research.”

“We’re making headway,” Asha said. “Fred coming on board is a big step in cutting down on our timetables. With a little luck and a lot of coffee, we might be able to get it down in a few days. Maybe a week more, at most.”

Ainsley didn’t exactly seem thrilled with the news, but she accepted it with a stalwart sigh. “Very well. I know that no delicate work is helped along by hurrying. If you’ll excuse me, I’m going to go have a word with my brother about his ‘guests’ and their understanding of where the bathrooms are.”

With a graceful twirl that sent her robes spinning, Ainsley strode back out of the room. Though no one touched them, the doors gently closed behind her, and I could hear the lock sliding back into place.

“Well, that was certainly something.” I sank back down into my chair and set about the task of finding the spot where I’d been interrupted in my work.

“Ainsley’s got a good heart. She’s just a little brash,” Asha told me. “It

doesn't help that her method of dealing with stress seems to be work, and enchanting is off the table until we finish dividing the estate."

"Why is that, exactly? Are you trying to stop any new goods from being produced that might impact the figures?" I asked.

In response, Asha dug through a few files and pulled out a thick stack of papers. Unlike the pages all around us, these were yellow and weathered, the script scrawled across them a handwritten cursive. "This is Herbram's will. The actual instructions are just the top page, the rest is all spellcraft and enchantments that I can't make heads or tails of. As Ainsley and Zane explained it, the tools and the other really valuable stuff is being held in a sort of magical escrow. Not even they can get to those items, not until the estate is divided. Only when they're both satisfied will they sign the back page, and that's what undoes the spell."

Now *that* was an impressive escrow system. Carefully, I took the pages from Asha and read through them. The first one was indeed a will, or as little instruction as could be given and still constitute one, but the rest appeared to be nothing more than gibberish and runes. This time, I was certain the runes were moving, as I flipped a page and caught one in mid-slither. Amy might have been able to make sense of what everything was, but seeing as she'd mentally checked out and it didn't actually impact my job, I decided to just trust Asha.

"It's a smart system," I said, handing her back the stack of pages. "Though a bit inconvenient for his kids. Did he really think they were going to snatch everything up before it could be divided?"

"From the way Ainsley and Zane describe it, I get the feeling it was more concern about external threats," Asha replied. "In case the house didn't give it away, the Clovers are worth a lot of money. Keeping everything locked up until it has a rightful owner was Herbram's way of making sure nothing got lost, or taken, in the handover. You can add magic and vampires, but good old corporate espionage is still the same all over."

"Well, the old clients didn't challenge for blood when they got robbed," I pointed out.

"See, that statement is how I know you were in the office too much. If you'd been out schmoozing, you'd know just how many blood oaths people were swearing." Asha tucked the will back under her file of financial records and pulled a ledger forward. "I've actually been surprised by how mundane a lot of my work is. Aside from almost every parahuman species having their own treaties, laws, and exceptions, there's really no difference from working with humans."

"Except for the occasional outburst of chaos and danger," I said.

"Do you get a lot of that? My closest call was in Charlotte Manor, and once when I mixed up my dates for a meeting with a weretiger. She thought I

was a trespasser, until she noticed the briefcase.”

“Give it time; soon, you’ll build up quite the stock of stories. Seems to come with the territory,” I told her.

Asha’s mouth was open to reply, but her words were lost as the sound of a thunderclap tore through the room, shaking everything around us like a three-second earthquake. It was so loud that it woke Bubba, who tried to sit up, got confused, and tumbled to the floor. Even Amy seemed to shake off her lingering stupor, turning her vacant gaze from the ceiling to a nearby window. I followed her eyes, looking out to see a red glow flickering through the glass.

Moving carefully, lest another blast shake the room, I carefully peered out to see what was causing the light show. I thought maybe one of the drunken guests had found a propane tank to set off, creating the explosion and setting the yard on fire. What met my eyes was not panicking guests and a blazing yard, however. The red glow was actually coming from the sky, which seemed too close for comfort, slicing down and parting the driveway less than a quarter of the way out, forming an opaque red wall that carried on in every visible direction.

What was more worrying was that everyone seemed to have vanished. No wait staff, no partygoers, no valets. Just empty buffet tables and glasses of fizzing champagne slowly going flat. Bubba, Asha, and Amy crowded around me as we took in the scene, trying to figure out exactly what had happened. From a few inches away, I heard Asha mutter darkly under her breath.

“You just had to go and tempt fate, didn’t you, Fred?”

## 4.

Amy pulled out a small bottle with several symbols etched on the side, popped the top, and took a long gulp. When she finished, the shapeless blobs around her eyes dissolved, although she had grown a small set of horns just below her hairline. I honestly couldn't have cared less about the new forehead accessories; all that mattered to me was that our resident alchemist was visibly more focused than before. As the only one of us who even remotely understood magic, we were all waiting for her to shed some light on what had just happened.

"Well, I'll be damned," Amy said, after looking at the scene with fresh focus. "I have no idea what the hell that is."

"I thought you were a mage." Asha's tone was strained; she was understandably a bit on edge given the circumstances.

"I'm an alchemist. That's like asking a dermatologist to fill in for an advanced brain surgeon. Sure, they're both doctors, but they've got specialties that the other wouldn't be as educated in, and this is some of high-level enchanter shit." Amy pointed to the red wall, as if we weren't already staring at it. "Best guess, this thing is a giant bubble that split us off into a pocket dimension."

"Seems like a big ass pocket," Bubba rumbled, having finally wiped the last of the sleep from his eyes.

"Just a phrase. It means we're not quite in the real world at the moment, sort of compacted into a magical space that's adjacent to it. I can explain if you really want me to, but the basic theory takes five heavy books and half a day to cover," Amy offered.

"We'll take your word for it." I scanned the area outside, still searching for any signs of life. "The bigger questions are: how did we get here, where is everyone, and what do we do to get home?"

"Look!" Asha grabbed my arm and pulled me a few inches over, shifting my perspective so that I caught sight of a suit-wearing figure just barely visible from our vantage point. Whoever they were, I could see them making broad gestures with their hands, either talking in an animated manner or perhaps casting a spell.

"Seems like we've got someone to question," Bubba said.

There was no discussion of the issue. He was right, and there was no getting around that. We needed to figure out what was happening, and there was at least a chance that the person down there might know. Amy fiddled with the lock, flinging the doors open to reveal an empty hallway. No guards,

no sounds of guests from downstairs; just a whole lot more nothing, exactly like the lawn. Moving swiftly, but with our eyes peeled for any potential danger, we made our way down the stairs.

“Holy crap.” Asha’s voice was a whisper as she veered away from the group. We’d just hit the bottom floor, and while the rest of us were occupied with getting outside, something else had caught the lawyer’s eye. It didn’t take long to notice what, either. Directly before her, hovering in mid-air, was a glass filled halfway with scotch. A few feet away was a dish piled high with large shrimp, right next to a floating glass of wine.

All around us, bits of dishware and cutlery hung about, supported by some invisible force. Bubba stuck a finger in a flute of champagne and gave it a quick swirl, watching the bubbles fizz in reaction to his touch. Then he took hold of the glass and tried to move it. Not so much as even a budge, and I knew well that Bubba’s strength was nothing to turn a nose up at.

“Are these what the guests were holding?” Asha asked, picking up a shrimp and turning it around in her hand before dropping it to the floor. The crustacean tumbled unimpeded, hitting the fine marble below us with a moist squish.

“Must be,” I agreed. “But why just the glasses and dishes? If it’s what they were holding, there was bound to be other stuff.”

“These are part of the mansion.” Amy’s head was tilted backward, staring up at the underside of a plate. “They all bear the Clover crest. Whatever happened, it kept the mansion, and every piece of property inside, intact.”

“Somehow, I think that’s even creepier.” Asha shuddered and walked back over to us. With the mystery of the floating dishware solved, or as solved as it was likely to be, we continued on, heading down the long hallway and out into the night air.

The four of us stepped into an argument, but it took me several seconds to realize that a fight was even happening, I was so distracted by the feeling of the air around me. It was completely still, unnaturally so, and a part of my more primal mind reeled at the incongruity. Outside was meant to be alive, the air always moving, slight currents bringing in new smells and feelings. None of that was here, though. This air was flat. Empty.

Dead.

“Oh, fuck you, it’s my fault! Was I supposed to just let you hex me?” The voice snapped me out of my fixation with the air, turning my attention to the pair of people bickering nearby. One I knew right away—the large staff and green robes made Ainsley unmistakable, even if her back was turned to us. The other person was the one wearing the suit that I’d seen from the window. Without introduction, I instantly knew that this would be Zane, the other Clover sibling. He and Ainsley were nearly identical, only a few small facial differences between them, despite being of different genders. If that weren’t

enough, though, I likely could have pieced it together from the foot-long wooden wand glowing a soft blue in his hand, runes just like the ones in Ainsley's staff scrawled across it.

"If you were half-decent, you'd have taken the spell. Stars know you deserve worse. Do you have any idea what I walked in on your *guests* doing in the restroom?" Ainsley yelled, waving her staff around as though she were debating taking it to her brother's head, which actually seemed quite in the realm of possibility from how heated things were.

"No, and I don't care. It's a party! That's why I pay people to clean up when these things are over."

"This is our home, you bastard, the Clover estate. Do you have no regard for the generations of our family that spent their lives in this mansion? What I am even asking, we both know the answer is no," Ainsley spat.

"Kiss my ass with the Clover estate shit. It's just a house! Quit trying to memorialize everything like it's so damned precious. Dad's gone; turning the home into a shrine won't bring him back!" Zane threw his hands about as he talked, which explained the erratic gestures I'd noticed from the window.

Ainsley opened and closed her mouth several times, but no words were coming out. I did notice that her grip on the staff had grown tighter, though, and suddenly, the inadvertent silence seemed like a good place to announce ourselves, before there was only one conscious mage to talk to.

"Excuse us, but I'm hoping you two have some idea of what's going on?" I tried to keep my voice calm and easygoing, but both of the Clover siblings easily jumped half a foot off the ground at the sound of my words. They spun around, staff and wand leveled at our group, before Ainsley finally seemed to recognize us.

"What . . . Fred? How did you four get here?" She threw a look to Zane, who merely shrugged, their feud momentarily forgotten amidst the mystery of our appearance.

"Sort of what we were hoping you could tell us," Asha replied. "We were up in the study, working on the will, when there was a loud boom and suddenly, this red bubble is everywhere and we're in some sort of purse dimension."

"Pocket dimension," Amy, Zane, and Ainsley all corrected simultaneously.

"*Whatever*," Asha snapped. "Point is, we're here, there are plates and glasses floating around, and it's not a great work environment. Can you fix this?"

While I didn't know much about the history between Ainsley and Zane, or their personalities, I easily recognized the sheepish, guilty look that flashed between them at Asha's question. We weren't going to like the answer, and they were probably going to be embarrassed by it.

“Here’s the issue,” Zane said, taking over the conversation with a smooth delicacy that I immediately envied. “This whole thing was our doing, sort of, but in a much bigger way, it’s the work of our father. Raising a pair of mages in the city can be troublesome, especially twins, since, like all kids, we would quarrel. And since he was the one who enchanted our staff and wand respectively, he added a little something extra. Every time spells from our tools clashed, the magical implements would trigger a spell that stuck us in our own pocket dimension. He did it partly to make sure we couldn’t go around using our magic in front of humans before we understood the consequences, but also as a punishment. This is the equivalent of our time-out room, and my dear sister activated it when she came storming downstairs in a tizzy and tried to launch a hex at me.”

“That ain’t much of an explanation on why we got dragged along,” Bubba said.

“Yeah, that I don’t know about,” Zane admitted. “Usually, the only things that come with us are our tools and possessions. Dad could walk in and out, since he created it, but he was the only one.”

“I’ve got a theory.” Ainsley stepped forward, though I noticed she kept several feet between herself and Zane at all times. “They were locked in the study when you callously blocked a spell you deserved and trapped us here. Father placed more than a tome’s worth of enchantments and wards on that room, so it’s possible that one of those spells tethered everything in it to our location, people included.”

“It’s as good a bet as any,” Zane agreed. “Dad loved to test new spells around the house. I wouldn’t put it past him to have thrown a pointless one on the study and forget about it.”

“He did *not* cast pointless spells.” Ainsley whirled around on Zane, a new head of steam already building for a fresh fight. But it was Amy, thankfully, who stepped forward and retook control of the situation.

“Look, we get that you two have shit to work out, and that’s great, but maybe we could focus on how to get out of your time-out space? I’m pretty sure the party guests have noticed that all their plates vanished, and eventually, someone will realize that the homeowner is gone, too.”

“No, Dad made this place to keep us from exposing our magic,” Zane said. “Just like space, the time is compressed. We’d have to spend months here before any measurable time slipped by on the outside.”

“He’d leave us in the bubble for weeks sometimes,” Ainsley added. “Bringing by food and water if needed, but otherwise, we’d be on our own.”

“Wow, and I thought my dad was strict,” Asha muttered.

“To the old man’s credit, we could get out anytime we wanted to.” Zane tilted his head toward Ainsley and rolled his eyes. “All we ever had to do was apologize to each other. Since we always went in here for fighting, he didn’t



let us out until we made up. But someone never learned to lie well enough to sell him on the fake ones, so it took much longer than needed.”

“Excuse me for not wanting to deceive our father,” Ainsley shot back.

“Okay, look, your dad’s not here to judge the authenticity of an apology, so why don’t you both just say you’re sorry and get us out of here,” Amy suggested.

Another look flashed between them. It wasn’t much, but it was enough that I knew, even before Zane spoke, that things wouldn’t be quite so simple.

“Yeah, see, the apology was what he demanded before letting us out, but it didn’t end the spell on its own,” Zane admitted. “For that, we need the chime of a clearing bell; the same one he used when creating the enchantment.”

“So, where’s the damn bell?” Bubba asked. Now it was my and Asha’s turn to exchange looks, as we both had the exact same hunch on what the answer would be. And unfortunately, we were dead-on right.

“We don’t have the exact location.” Ainsley’s eyes were suddenly very preoccupied with the grass down by her feet. “All we know is that it’s with the rest of his enchanting tools, locked away in magical escrow.”

## 5.

Fierce as my own initial rising panic was, I was far more concerned with how Asha would take the news. Bubba, Amy, and I were all accustomed to a certain level of chaos popping up at unexpected times. Asha, however, was new to the parahuman world, only being acquainted with it for a few months. There was a very real chance that the terror of such an impossible magical predicament could overwhelm her, and we needed everyone functional if we hoped to break out of this pocket bubble.

To my shock, Asha looked cheerier than she had in the foyer of floating plates. If anything, she seemed relieved by the news, which only served to make me wonder if I'd misheard Ainsley's explanation.

"Asha, are you okay?"

"Huh?" She looked over at me, more perplexed by the question than the issue of how we were going to escape. "Sure. I mean, I was worried for a while there, but it looks like this will be an easy fix, after all."

Zane and Ainsley were shooting expressions at Asha that perfectly mirrored my own. "Perhaps being locked in the study made you forget, but escrow means there's no getting at the tools until we've decided who the owner is," Zane told her.

"Right, which is exactly what Fred is here to help me do," Asha agreed, still unbothered by our dour dispositions. "And this is better in a lot of ways. We've got however long we need to do the work, since time doesn't matter, and according to you, no one will even notice that we're gone. All we have to do is iron out the will, and whoever gets the tools can pop us out of here."

"Don't mean to be a party pooper, but there's the issue of food and water to think about." Bubba spoke between bites of shrimp; evidently, he'd taken a handful from the plates in the foyer. I'd have been worried about someone noticing the absent crustaceans when the time bubble vanished, but with the amount of alcohol I'd seen flowing, I sincerely doubted anyone would assume missing shrimp were stolen by a giant therian.

Ainsley lifted her head slightly higher. Now that the situation wasn't so hopeless, it seemed she didn't feel quite as ashamed for getting us into it. "We've got enough bottled water and food in the panty to last for months. Father always used to say that a mage's home should be a fortress unto itself, impregnable and self-sufficient."

It seemed Herbram Clover shared the same thoughts on home-safety as the mages who had built Charlotte Manor. I could only wonder what his children would think of my friend, the animated house.

“And do you also have a stock of blood on hand?” In the silence that fell after Amy’s words, every eye slowly turned to me. Asha was scared, and trying not to show it, having no doubt only just remembered that, as a vampire, I needed blood to survive. Ainsley and Zane both looked more concerned than fearful, regarding me as a potential threat that might need dealing with. Bubba and Amy were worried, but there was no terror in their anxiety. They knew the situation from my vantage point, and understood that the biggest potential issue was me starving myself, as I had no desire to take anyone’s blood, especially unwillingly.

“Never let it be said that I am unprepared.” Reaching into my back pocket, I pulled out the enchanted flask I’d purchased in Boarback. “Had a run-in with an unfriendly fellow several weeks ago, and ever since, I’ve made a point of always keeping some emergency blood on hand. Just in case.”

A wave of relief washed over the rest of the room. With my own meals handled, there was nothing to stop us from buckling down and pushing through the paperwork. If anything, this might be a blessing in disguise. Instead of having to carve days out of my schedule to work in, Asha and I could handle the whole thing in one marathon of number crunching.

“Seems as though you’ve got work to do,” Zane said, nicely summing up the situation. It might have been that easy, too, if only he hadn’t kept talking. “But after tonight’s attack, it can no longer be denied that my sister lacks the temperament to run this business. Divide the resources fairly, just make sure that I get the enchanting tools, regardless of how much else you have to give her.”

“You? Your skills aren’t even up to what Father could do, yet you want to take over his business?” Ainsley whirled on her brother, staff trembling in her angry grip.

“My work won’t be as good as what you can manage.” There was no bitterness or bite in Zane’s voice; it was like he’d accepted the truth of the statement so long ago that it no longer hurt him to utter it. “But all the skillful enchanting in the world doesn’t matter if you yell at the clients and scare them away. I can build the Clover business beyond where Dad left it. Meanwhile, you’d be lucky to still get any jobs after a year.”

“The Clover name is about quality. Our enchanting is some of the highest caliber on the market!” Ainsley yelled. “People pay for *that*, not because you buy them a few rounds of champagne and tell them what they want to hear.”

“We’re not the only high-level enchanters out there. Without that champagne and ass-kissing, they’ll take their business elsewhere.” Zane was a curious contrast to Ainsley. As she was getting more worked up, he seemed to be getting calmer and more detached. It was like watching an ocean smash against a boulder; there was plenty of movement and action, but ultimately, nothing was changed in the end.

“That’s why our work has to get better, so there’s no one out there who can compete with what we do.” Ainsley turned from her brother to Asha, though she needn’t have bothered. All of us, even Bubba and Amy, already knew what Ainsley was going to say.

“Unless I get the tools in the split, I’m not going to sign.”

“For once, my sister and I see eye-to-eye on something,” Zane said. “I, too, am going to have to hold firm on the condition that I be the one to carry on Dad’s business. It’s the enchanter tools, or no signature.”

“Oh, *come on*.” Asha threw her hands up in the air, a motion I’d thought existed only in expressions, until I actually saw her get so frustrated she didn’t know how else to show it. “You realize how impossible that is, don’t you? We can’t give you both the tools, and we need the damn things to get out of here. You’re literally holding us all hostage by being too petty to compromise.”

“You have my sincere apologies,” Zane said, and admittedly, he did sound pretty darn sincere. “I don’t take any joy in dragging you into this; however, I can’t let my sister undo generations of family achievement by driving off all of our customers. Maybe this seems petty to you, and you might not be wrong, but this business was Dad’s pride and joy. I have to protect it, and if that means inconveniencing you, then so be it. There’s plenty of food and water to live on, and I’ll pay your respective rates until we break free. Consider it a working sabbatical.”

“Do we have rates?” Bubba whispered to Amy, who shrugged her shoulders. It was unlikely either of them had thought about billing, since they were just pitching in as a favor to Richard, but I’d make sure to calculate one for each of them before the matter was settled. I’d be damned if I’d see my friends get nothing for the trouble of living in a pocket dimension.

“Zane’s right,” Ainsley added. “This is more than just a business. It’s the Clover legacy. I’ll do whatever it takes to make sure it’s carried on properly, by me.”

“Again, you’re handing us an impossible task.” Asha looked between the stone-faced twins, trying to appeal to their sense of reason. “We can’t give you both the tools. One of you has to cave on this.”

“Then I suggest you make a compelling proposal,” Zane said. “Convince one of us that what you’re offering in the split is a better deal. Otherwise, it’s a matter of seeing who breaks first.”

“Oh, I think we already know who that will be. You love your precious parties too much to be away from them for long. All I need is a workspace and a library to be happy. In fact, I’ve got some experiments to check on. Let me know when the papers are ready to be signed.” With that, Ainsley stomped off into the mansion, nearly knocking over several champagne flutes with the wide swings of her wooden staff.

As she vanished, Zane seemed to deflate, the confidence and surety he'd used to hold back her anger falling away. It wasn't that he seemed less charismatic, just more weary. He watched his sister go before turning to the rest of us.

"Again, I am genuinely sorry for all of this. How about, for now, you focus on getting the assets fairly divided, like you already were. I'll try and think of a way to make Ainsley come around by then. For now, though, I think I need a little time to recuperate." Zane slipped into the foyer then as well, moving carefully between the plates so that nothing would be disturbed. He didn't climb the stairs, however. Instead, he grabbed an unopened bottle of champagne off the table and headed to the left, toward a part of mansion I'd yet to lay eyes on.

"Might as well make myself useful," Bubba declared. "I'm gonna go take stock of the pantry, see what we've got in terms of food. Got a hunch that neither of those two is much for cookin', so I'll earn my keep by makin' sure we all stay fed."

"I'll try and see if anything I've got can break us out of here." Amy swung her bag around and began to rummage through it. While it only looked large enough to hold a few books and perhaps a water bottle, I'd seen, more than once, just how much bigger it was on the inside. "Don't think I have any potions that can break dimensional walls, but there's nothing like necessity to spur innovation."

"Let's call that Plan Z." Bubba tilted his head toward me and Asha. "Best case is these two gettin' the twins to settle their differences."

Asha threw a look of hope in my direction, but the best I could muster was a weak grin that was supposed to be reassuring. This was a family matter, and I'd done enough estate work to know those were always more complicated. As much as they claimed it was about the business, there were also decades of fighting, disagreements, and other troubles to contend with, all compacted by the sense of loss at their father's passing. I wasn't sure anything we said or did was going to move them before they were ready.

But even if that was the case, we still had to get the estate division done. Until that part was handled, it was impossible to proceed. So, with no other options, I motioned to Asha, and we headed back to the study.

## 6.

Time was functionally meaningless inside the bubble. Sure, the clocks moved, but with no day or night cycle, only the ever-present red glow of the wall cutting us off from reality, it all just blurred together. The moment we'd been trapped in was nighttime, though, which mattered only in that I never felt the familiar wave of weariness crash over me, signaling that the sun had risen. I wasn't sure if that was a good thing or not, as I'd already gone far longer than usual without the cathartic release of a long day's rest. Still, I didn't feel too loopy or out of it yet, so I pushed on. It wasn't as if I could change the situation, even if I wanted to. My best bet would be asking Amy for a potion, and there was no way something that specific wouldn't be experimental. As I've said before, Amy's alchemy skills are highly praised and impressive, but even she has to break a few eggs in the process of creation.

Instead of fretting about how long a vampire could retain their sanity without sleep, I focused on getting the work done. Asha and I holed up in the study with her files, working tirelessly to account for every asset, owning, and piece of property in the Clover estate. When she slept, I worked on calculating the value for the tools, poring through old receipts for work done, trying to quantify what the trends in the enchanting market were and extrapolating how much they could earn over the next several decades. It's not my place to speak about a client's finances, but suffice to it say that when I finally finished assigning those items a value, there were a *lot* of zeroes behind it. More impressively, though, there was enough of the estate to make up for the split, assuring each of the siblings an even cut of the inheritance.

Of course, the real problem was that neither of them would accept the half without tools, and that didn't seem to be changing anytime soon. Bubba gave us reports when he came in with meals for Asha. Ainsley only let him in to deliver food, having locked herself away in her workshop, and Zane was in the wine cellar, slowly carving his way through the offerings of every region in France. Neither was talking, except to say that they weren't going to budge.

"We have to do something." The words came out of nowhere, Asha and I having fallen into what had become our usual silence as we worked on organizing the assets. She broke that silence, looking up from her work with a pinched, tired expression on her face. "Judging by how often I've slept, it's been three days in here, and I'm going to lose it pretty soon." Evidently, I was wrong about time being meaningless, at least for those who still had mortal bodies to keep track of.

"We're almost done," I said. It was meant to be a hopeful statement, but

the words only highlighted the larger issue at hand. We'd been focusing on the work because it was what we could do. Once that was over, we'd have nothing else. It became a waiting game to see which of the twins would break first.

"That's the problem." Asha laid her hand on the thick stack of parchment that was Herbram's enchanted will. "A few more hours of ironing out the detail work, tops, and we're finished. Unless we can think of a way to find another set of enchanting tools passed through their family, we're going to be stuck here."

"Is that an option? Not inherited tools, I mean, but this set has a value. Could we get a set that's comparable in terms of power?"

"Doesn't seem likely," Asha replied. "You've seen how important these are to the family; my understanding is that most mages treat the really potent stuff the same way. Even if there was an open market for them, it doesn't help us in here. That's the sort of deal we'd have to have in place before one of them was willing to sign."

"And splitting the items up is off the table?" I'd gone through the history of every piece in Herbram's enchanting tool kit as I assessed their cumulative value; there were six, in total. If only the twins were willing to divvy them up, then perhaps we could get out of here.

"Doing that would mean they either both get a weakened set, or have to agree to work together." Asha jerked a thumb toward the window, where that familiar red glow still lingered in place. "These really seem like the kind of people who are willing to work together?"

"Sadly, no," I admitted. "Though they'd clearly be better off if they were willing to do so. I can't imagine what's stirred up so much animosity between them."

"I've got a guess," Asha said. "We both know this stuff is newer to me than it is to you, but I did a little research when I got offered the job. From what I can tell, Herbram telling his kids to split the inheritance however they saw fit is an oddity in the mage world. Normally, Herbram would have bequeathed the tools specifically to one of his children, essentially choosing which of them he trusted to continue his work. When he didn't do that, he left them both out of sorts. Neither knows who he wanted to have take over, which makes it all the more important to prove themselves by doing so."

"Huh. I am beginning to suspect that Herbram Clover might have been something of an asshole."

"Or just didn't understand how things are between siblings." Asha stood from the desk, taking a long stretch that produced audible pops from her back. "I think I'm going to ask Ainsley for a shower to use. Living in these clothes for the past three days hasn't been my idea of fun, and I'm sure it's no treat for you either."

I hadn't mentioned it, for obvious reasons, but there are precious few humans that can go unwashed for three days and not be picked up by vampiric nostrils. Thankfully, my selective attention was excellent, so I'd put the inevitable scent of sweat and time out of mind, right up until she mentioned it.

"While I'm up there, I'll see if I can make any headway with her, competitive sister to competitive sister. Maybe you can drum up a conversation with Zane," Asha suggested.

"I'm afraid I don't have any siblings to use as common ground," I said.

"No, but if memory serves, you know your way around a bottle of wine. Seems like common enough ground to start with." She finished her stretch, laid a pen between the pages of a ledger to mark her spot, and made her way out into the hall.

I worked for a while longer, both to find a good stopping point and to try to plan out what on earth I could say to Zane that would move things forward. Not surprisingly, nothing sprang to mind. Aside from us being trapped in a dimension cut off from the real world, it was hard to argue with either his or Ainsley's points. Alone, either of them would falter, Ainsley's temper driving off customers while Zane's skill lowered their reputation for quality. With enough work and training, one of them might be able to grow and overcome the limitation, but there would still be lost ground to recover.

Eventually, I faced the fact that no brilliant bolt of insight was going to strike me and rose from the desk to head downstairs. Brooding wasn't productive, and if I talked to Zane, there was a chance I might uncover something that could get us free. The trip down was quick, though I got a bit turned around near the kitchen, as I'd only seen bits of the massive estate. Fortunately, I finally remembered that people who spend their days in wine cellars don't tend to take shower breaks, so I sniffed around until I located Zane's pungent scent. From there, it was just a matter of tracking it through an empty house and down into a wine cellar bigger than my apartment.

I'll admit, for as much as I like to think myself wise enough to be content with my own earnings, I was filled with jealousy at the sight of their cellar. Climate-controlled, gently lit, and filled with rows upon rows of gleaming bottles. The ones I recognized, which were fewer than I'd expected, were the sort of vintage that sat near the top of wine lists in fancy restaurants, serving as conversation fodder for what kind of person would spend so much money on a single bottle of alcohol. Red, white, even the odd rosé, all lined up in rows upon rows of carefully sorted bottles. It was like walking into a wine library, or museum, and I idly wondered how big my business would have to grow to justify this level of extravagance.

The sound of clinking glass drew my attention to one of the rows at the far end of the room, where I discovered Zane leaning against a wall, a bottle of



merlot in one hand and a burrito in the other. At least Bubba had been making sure the mage didn't wallow on an empty stomach. Slowly, I made my way over, though it wasn't until I was less than a few feet away that Zane bothered looking up.

"Ah, there's my undead worker. How's the will coming?" His voice was a little slurred, though not nearly as bad as I'd expected from the number of empty bottles rolling around near him. Perhaps he'd been going slower than the rest of us realized, or maybe mages had a higher tolerance than I knew. Neil was too young to drink, and Amy tended to prefer her own work, so I didn't have a great example to work from.

"It's almost done," I told him. "We've found a way to split it all up evenly. The last part is determining which of you gets the tools."

"Those damned things." Zane lifted the bottle to his lips and found it nearly empty, so he set it aside and began to search for another.

"Here." I grabbed one of the few wines I recognized from the shelf, a cabernet sauvignon that I'd always wanted to try, and handed it to him. "You may as well stick to red, since you've made the commitment."

"An excellent idea." Instead of reaching for a wine opener, he pulled out his wand and mumbled what sounded like gibberish under his breath before tapping it to the top of the bottle. To my surprise, the cork began to worm its way upward, eventually dislodging and falling to the ground with a small *pop*. He took a long draw from the bottle, then offered it to me. "Care for a sip?"

"You should really decant something like this first." I took the bottle anyway and slid down to the ground next to him, taking a deep whiff of the wine before allowing it to actually hit my tongue.

"It's just the cheap stuff." He leaned back, letting his head rest on the cool stone wall behind us. "Always assumed they'd go to Ainsley, you know." It was a bit of a topic jump, but with how little we'd both talked, I had no problem sussing out his meaning.

"The tools?"

"Of course, the tools. She's a better enchanter than me. Better than Dad, too, and he had over a century of experience on her."

It was a good thing I'd yet to sip the wine, because I would have snorted it out at his words. I knew that mages lived longer than most people, though I'd never thought to ask why, but over a century . . . that was more than I'd been expecting.

"It just seemed like a lock, you know," Zane continued, either unaware or unbothered by the surprise in my face. "Ainsley was the one who could do the best enchanting, so she would be the one who got the tools. I was just the guy who did the talking, worked the deals, and got us a few extra percents on the bottom line."

"That's nothing to undersell," I told him. "Businesses live and die by their

profit margins.” Now that the wine’s scent had fully been appreciated, I allowed myself to take a small swallow from the bottle. It was so heavenly that for a moment I actually forgot the situation and just allowed myself to revel in the joy dancing along my tongue.

“Do we particularly look like we need the extra margins?” Zane gestured to the cellar, but he just as easily could have been pointing to the house, the estate, as a whole. “No one cared that I brought in more money; there was always so much of it. At least, that’s what I thought.”

I handed him back the bottle, which he took a glugging drink from, spilling more than a few drops down his neck to an already stained shirt. “What changed your mind?”

“Well, he didn’t leave the tools to Ainsley, did he? He left it up to us to figure out who should get them. Sort of felt like Dad was giving me a chance. Saying that I could get them, if I proved myself worthy.” He sighed and took another drink, then handed me back the bottle. “Instead, I’ve gotten into a pissing match with my sister just like when we were kids, dragged a lot of innocent people along for the ride, and hid away in the cellar. Truly, a son to be proud of.”

“In all fairness, Ainsley is being just as stubborn, and she’s locked herself in her workshop.” I’m not sure why I felt bad for Zane. He was part of the reason we were stuck, and none of things he just said were untrue. Even more, he seemed like the kind of person I should have despised. Wealthy, charismatic, and handsome, he’d been handed all the advantages in life that I hadn’t, yet I couldn’t bring myself to hold that against him. I guess I just knew a little too well what it was like to not be what your parents were hoping for.

“For her, this probably feels like a robbery. The tools were supposed to be hers, and now she’s scared of losing them to her screw-up of a brother. Can’t say I blame her for digging in. Truth is, Ainsley should get the tools. I understand it, you know, deep in my gut, but I just can’t bring myself to let go.” He pulled out his wand once more, rolling it gently between his fingers. “I’m a lot of things, and I’ve made peace with most of them. I just don’t want to be a quitter. I want to fight. I want to prove that I can make the old man proud, too.”

It was hard to think of a way to fault him, or to argue with that sentiment, so, instead, I just took another sip from the bottle of wine. Somehow, it wasn’t quite as magical as the first time around. Maybe I’d already gotten used to it, or, more likely, Zane’s sadness just made it impossible to find such joy in a fermented liquid.

I could see that he was nearing the breaking point, guilt slowly gaining on pride and determination. He’d break in a day or so on his own, and if I pushed him carefully, we might be free in the next few hours. Yet, to my own

surprise, now that the key to our escape was within reach, part of me didn't want it. Not like this. Zane was right; he deserved the chance to prove himself, just as Ainsley did.

And I was beginning to have an inkling of an idea of how to give them just that.

## 7.

Based on Bubba's meals and Asha's need for rest, it took another day to do the fresh contracts. We probably could have pounded them out in half the time if we'd raced through it, but the one good thing about being trapped in a timeless pocket dimension is that there's no compulsion to rush. Instead, Asha and I took our time, crossing every "t" and dotting every "i" to make sure our work was airtight. Given that we were dealing with mages and an enchanted will, it seemed prudent to leave no wiggle room anywhere in our documents. That was the sort of thing that would just open up more trouble down the line.

Finally, when we were sure the language was word-perfect, we waited until Bubba made a food delivery, and then asked him to bring everyone to the study. Less than ten minutes later, Ainsley, Bubba, Amy, and Zane entered the room, in that order. No words passed between the siblings as everyone took their seats, though Amy filled the silence by asking Bubba about his recipe for the omelets he'd made that "morning." When everyone was seated, I looked to Asha to start things off. She was the lawyer and main employee, after all. I was just the numbers guy.

"Before we get going, let me double check. Are either of you willing to let the other have the enchanting tools in exchange for the lion's share of the rest of the estate?" Asha's eyes darted between Zane and Ainsley, neither of whom spoke, though both looked far less stalwart than they had when first making their ultimatums. I had a hunch that, now that they had both cooled down, it was as much a matter of pride as it was actually wanting the inheritance.

"About what we expected," Asha continued. "Fine, then. You've forced Fred and me to really think outside the box on this one, since none of us want to spend the next forty years stuck in here. So, here is what we're proposing as a compromise."

That was my cue. I rose from the desk, contracts in hand, and made my way around the large table, now almost completely cleared off of all the clutter we'd needed to work with. I laid a stack of documents in front of Ainsley, then Zane, before returning to my seat, where an identical packet was already waiting. They began flipping through the pages the moment they got them, and before I was even settled, I heard Ainsley's voice echo through the room.

"Joint custody?"

"*Temporary* joint custody," Asha corrected. "Since neither of you is willing to give up your claim on the tools, it seemed like this was the best way

to determine who should get them. For the next year, you'll alternate days where the enchanting tools are yours to use. In that time, you will both work to build the Clover business as best you can. You'll find and book your own clients, do your own work, and make your own money. After a year's time, Fred and I will sit down to look at the numbers. Whoever does the best business will get the tools. Couldn't be more fair."

"Why should I have to compete for my rightful inheritance?" Ainsley demanded.

"Because it's not yours yet." I actually hadn't planned on speaking, but sometimes poor social skills means blurting out the things you didn't want to say as much as losing the chance to say the ones you did. Still, I'd stepped in it, so it seemed the best course of action was to press on. "Your father's will left you both equal claim to these tools. Maybe he did want you to have them; everyone seems to agree you're the better enchanter. But maybe he wanted you to earn them, rather than just be given them. This way, neither of you ever has to wonder if Herbram chose the right person to carry on the legacy. The winner will be the one who proves themselves most worthy."

My eyes may have flicked to Zane at that, and I caught sight of a small grin on the corner of his lips. To my surprise, Ainsley actually seemed to calm down as well. Maybe she and Zane weren't so different, after all; they both wanted the chance to show that they were the rightful heir.

"Now, obviously, there is always the chance that in the coming year you might need to work together on something," Asha said, bringing us back to the technical arrangements she and I had planned out. "The Clover name is a prestigious one, and Zane might find a client who needs an enchantment that even Herbram would have struggled with. In those cases, rather than doing a slipshod job or turning the client down altogether, there is a provision allowing him to work with Ainsley. You both get equal credit for the job, and the payment is split evenly into both your ledgers. Much as we want to see who the best is, I think we can all agree that preserving the Clover reputation is equally important."

Zane and Ainsley both nodded, almost in unison. It was possibly the first thing I'd seen them agree on since arriving at the mansion. Asha was visibly relieved; getting this far along meant that they weren't dismissing the idea outright. Truth be told, we didn't have a Plan B if this failed, aside from waiting for one of them to crack. For their sakes, I hoped they went along with our idea. It seemed a good bet that either one actually winning sole ownership of the tools would drive a wedge between them that would not be easily broken. And nothing, not even a generations-long legacy, was worth losing their family over.

"There is one more provision to discuss." Asha turned a page in her own packet, a signal for them to do the same, which neither twin picked up on.

“Should the year end and you decide that more time is needed, perhaps because there are joint projects to finish or business to wrap up, you can elect to not call us back for the review. In which case, the agreement rolls over for another year. However, and I cannot stress this enough, should that happen, then the rules change slightly.”

Zane and Ainsley leaned in closer, as did Bubba and Amy for some reason. I guess after being cooped up for so long, even contract discussion was exciting for them to watch.

“The first year is an impartial timeframe. You both start from the same place and get the same amount of time to work in,” Asha explained. “After that, it’s a little different. One of you could backend your business, destroy in the second year, and then call us in to review what looks like a successful business when it is really an emptied out pipeline. So, in the interest of fairness, if you collectively choose not to call us in at the end of the first year, the contract stays in effect until you both agree to have us make the determination. Neither of you gets to pull a fast one on the other. Any objections?”

“My sister and I sometimes have . . . issues . . . seeing eye-to-eye,” Zane said. “It might take a while before we can agree on a year when we both feel like we’ve got a shot at winning.”

Which, in truth, was exactly what Asha and I were counting on. These two were skillful in their own right, but neither would be as strong alone as they were together. If they could never agree on a year to bring us back, then they’d be stuck with each other, building the family business bigger and more respected than it ever was before. And, more importantly, neither had to lose or resent the other over their father’s legacy.

“Then just have us come in at the end of the first year,” Asha replied, keeping a far better poker face than I would have managed. “We added that stipulation for your benefit, not ours, in case you decide one year isn’t long enough. Either of you can call us to make the determination at the end of that first year. Of course, since this is a competition, I’d have to advise you to keep your books secret from one another. But honestly, they’re your records, do what you want with them.”

“About that . . .” Ainsley’s voice had cooled; quick as she was to anger, she was just as fast at letting it go—at least when not being continually provoked. “Zane and I aren’t really the best record keepers, and this seems like it requires a lot of that.”

“I’d recommend you both hire personal assistants, then,” Asha suggested. “You’ve got the cash for it, and I’m sure there are countless younger mages that would jump at the chance to work for the Clover family. Just to ensure accuracy though, Fred has agreed to do a quarterly review of both sets of books. For a fair rate, of course.”

Neither had an immediate argument for that; I was about as independent a party as they were going to get. Instead, they looked at each other across the table, for what might very well have been the first time they'd made eye contact since their initial fight.

"I'm okay with this if you are," Zane said, breaking the silence first. "We both get a fair shot at Dad's tools, and it's not the best enchanter or schmoozer that wins. It's whoever does the best business."

"My quality versus your quantity." Ainsley actually smiled as she spoke, nodding her head just a bit. "At least we can put the argument to bed. And I want you to know that, when I win, there will still be a place for you in the company. Those valets need supervising."

"I was about to say the same to you, though I was going to let you know that your new office will be in the corner of the basement," Zane teased back.

Just like that, the tension that had been filling the mansion since that red bubble first appeared began to dissipate. Asha pulled out several pens and slid them down to where the twins were sitting.

"Let's get you to sign those documents, and when you're happy with that, we can have you autograph Herbram's will and get the hell out of here."

"Sounds good to me," Zane agreed, reaching for a pen. "And, Ainsley, I'm sorry. Not just about this fight, but about all the partying lately. It's just that the mansion feels kind of . . . empty since Dad passed. I guess I was trying to avoid that as much as possible."

"I know," Ainsley said, picking up her own pen as well. "I always knew that was why you were doing it, but instead of leaving my workshop, I just shut the doors tighter. That's where he and I used to do most of our work, and if I got deep enough in a project, I could sort of forget that he was gone for a little while. But I should have come out to check on how you were doing, instead of leaving you alone. So, I'm sorry, too."

The loud pop that filled the air rattled the table, along with everything else in the room that was not bolted down. Right on the heels of the burst was the screech of music that I'd managed to forget was playing, along with the chatter of hundreds of people out on the lawn, moving about like nothing had happened. Which, for them, it hadn't.

We all stared at each other, momentarily shocked by the sudden change. All save for Amy, whose now glowing orange eyes merely swept the room before she gave a half-hearted shrug.

"Guess you just needed to apologize, after all."

## 8.

To my incredible relief, no longer being trapped inside a pocket dimension didn't dampen Ainsley and Zane's enthusiasm for the agreement. Asha and I walked them through the contracts, while Bubba and Amy helped the rest of the guards shut down the party. This was done half because we wanted less noise while working, and half because he and Amy had done a lot of cooking and alchemy experiments downstairs, which meant that the longer people were down there, the greater the chance of them noticing the sudden changes. Thankfully, the fight had come after the party was in full swing, which meant most of the guests were too liquored up to notice anything more than a few inches in front of them. Cars were pulled up, drivers taken off break, and one by one, the wealthy and well-dressed guests were hustled off the Clover property.

Meanwhile, we spent an hour and a half walking the twins through every page before they signed, making certain they understood what they were agreeing to. Anyone could see their eyes glaze over after the first fifteen minutes, but Asha and I were professionals, and as such, we were accustomed to that, just as we knew it didn't change our duty to explain it all anyway. Better bored for an hour than feeling swindled for a lifetime.

Finally, the guests were gone and the last signatures on our contracts were drying. Each got an equal share of the estate—which had been a much easier task after we'd pulled the tools out of the equation—and now, there was only one document left to sign, but it was by far the most important.

Herbram's will was as thick and largely illegible as ever. Asha set it down at the far end of the table, forcing both Zane and Ainsley to walk over to it. I'll confess that, up to this point, I'd been worried that there was some other aspect to signing that we weren't privy to. A magical quill, ink from their own blood, really anything along those lines. As it turned out, a cheap plastic pen and regular ink did the job, as each of the twins leaned over and scratched their signatures onto the bottom of the page. Unimpressive as the signing was, what came next was a sight to behold.

Just as Zane finished scrawling out his name, the pages began to glow a faint red, not unlike the bubble that had held us prisoner for so long. They began to twitch before he'd even fully backed away, quickly escalating to a full flutter, like the wind was rustling only the pages and nothing else in the room. The movements grew more and more violent, until the pages flew up from the table, swirling around the room in an intangible tornado. They danced all around us, always coming close but never quite making contact,



before they began to head back to the end of the table. Rather than landing in a pile, however, each page seemed to fold as it drew closer, pressing into the others that had already taken shapes of their own. In less than a minute, they'd all landed, folding and connecting to form a large red box. Slowly, the glow began to fade, and I could see that the object was no longer made of paper. No, now it was a smooth metal covered in rapidly fading runes, zero seams or signs that it had ever been formed from dozens of separate pages.

Ainsley and Zane both reached forward, touching the front of the box. The moment they made contact, a door formed, swinging open to reveal several gems, a pile of scrolls, and one black bag with a single silver buckle in the center. Stylized on the front of the buckle's shiny surface was an ornate "C." The Clover family enchanting tools had finally been recovered, it seemed.

"Smaller than I expected," Asha said, tilting her head to get a good view into the box.

"Trust me, there's more to it than meets the eye." Ainsley reached forward and tenderly picked up the bag, cradling it like one would an infant. "The bag alone is enchanted with the work of countless ancestors, and it's easily the least magical part of the set." Slowly, she extended her arms, holding out the black bag to her brother. "It's past midnight, so today is the fourteenth. You get the tools on even days. Part of the contract."

"I guess it was." Zane accepted the handoff, though he was visibly uncomfortable pulling them from his sister's hands. For several long seconds, there was silence as he held the prize they'd dragged us through time and space to claim for themselves. "You know, we're pretty backed up on orders that came in before Dad died. Maybe we should work together to clear those out before the competition officially begins. Keep the clients happy and give ourselves an even start."

"Is that allowed?" Ainsley looked at Asha, who managed little more than a shrug.

"Your business. Run it how you want. We just get called in to check the results."

"Then I think that's a good idea," Ainsley told Zane. He offered her back the bag, which she accepted. "Let's go move everything somewhere safe, first."

Zane nodded, reaching into the box that was once a will and scooping up the remainder of the contents. The two of them left the study then, discussing which project to start with, not that I really understood the minutia of what they were talking about. Numbers, I got. Magic was a whole other animal.

As the sound of their voices faded up the stairs, Asha and I looked at each other as we finally gave in to the sense of relief. The job was done, we were out of the pocket dimension, and we'd managed to make both our clients happy. Plus, we were going to be able to bill for several days of working

hours at an overtime rate, which always made a hard job more palatable.

“Are you thinking what I’m thinking?” Asha asked.

“Get out of here as quickly as possible, before they get into another fight and we’re stuck in the bubble again?” I ventured.

“Damn, I was going to say a stiff glass of scotch, but that idea makes a lot more sense. Let’s pack it up.” Asha headed back over to the table, unplugging her laptop and stuffing the copies of the contracts into her bag. “You did good work, by the way, Fred. I’ll keep you in mind if I ever need an accounting consult again.”

“In this town, there aren’t many other options,” I warned her. “But I’d still appreciate the call. Hopefully, I’ll be able to take whatever you throw my way. Though, to be honest, my schedule is uncomfortably full these days.”

“Lot of demand and very little supply. Part of why I made the jump over to parahuman work,” Asha said. “But you know how business works, if you’re in that high of demand, just increase your rates. The smaller clients will fall away and you’ll be able to get more for your time.”

“I guess.” Asha was right, that was how any introductory business class would advise me to handle being so overworked. Then again, those classes hadn’t gotten to meet and interact with all the parahumans I’d helped. Most of them didn’t have money like the Clovers or Richard. They were just working-class people trying to get by, and I was able to help them do that. I wasn’t cheap, by any means, but I also didn’t price myself out of affordability. If I upped my rates significantly, I’d have more money and free time. All it would mean was turning my back on the less-wealthy parahumans.

“I remember that look.” Asha’s voice pulled me out of the reverie I didn’t know I’d fallen into. She was staring at me, an unexpected expression of concern on her face. “You used to get that way when word came down from the Torvalds to drop a client so we could move resources to someone more profitable. I think that’s why I remembered you even after you quit. A whole department of accountants, and you were one of the few who saw the clients as more than numbers.”

“More of us do than you’d think,” I told her. “Torvald & Torvald just had a knack for recruiting the more ruthless among my profession.”

“Sort of missed the mark with you, didn’t they?”

“Well, I’m not ruthless, but my accuracy rates certainly looked like I was trying to shame everyone.” I tucked away my laptop and the few papers needed to log the hours I’d put in. “And if I can, I’d rather expand the client-base than shrink it. That’s also good business sense.”

“Good luck with that.” Asha zipped up her bag and threw it over her shoulder. “I’ll keep an ear to the ground, just in case I run across a therian looking to do an internship.”

“With my luck, they’ll think my company is a front for something more

impressive and get bored as soon as they realize it really is just accounting.” We headed out of the study and began walking down the stairs. Asha and I were in the foyer when I heard Zane calling our names.

We turned to see him rushing over with a bottle in each hand. “Glad I caught you two. Ainsley and I wanted to say thank you for all your help. And, obviously, apologize for the inconvenience. We’ll process your bills as soon as they come, but for now, this is a token of our gratitude.”

He held out each bottle, one of scotch for Asha and a merlot for me. I didn’t even remotely recognize the label or brand, but from the way Asha’s eyes went wide, I had a feeling she knew what hers was, and my wine was probably just as rare and valuable.

“This is a bit much as a thank you,” Asha protested.

“Agreed, the rates cover our work,” I added.

“Sorry, I think you’ll find these bonuses non-negotiable.” Zane held up his hands and backed away, cutting off all attempts to return the bottles. “You two went above and beyond what anyone could ask of you. Here in the Clover family, we believe in saying thanks for that kind of dedication. And if either of you ever need any enchanting done, I think we can manage a sharp discount. Friends and family price, if you will.”

Asha merely nodded, but I responded. “Thank you very much. I may take you up on that one day.” Having glimpsed the tip of what magic could do, I wasn’t going to turn down such an offer out of hand. One never knew what sort of needs might arise in the future.

“I hope you do, because I really mean it.” Zane snapped his fingers and pointed at me, nearly causing me to drop the bottle of probably priceless wine. “Speaking of, Fred, are you associated with the House of Turva? I checked over the pending orders, and we’ve got a large request for sunlight-proof glass from them. I don’t want to haggle too hard if they’re your people.”

“N-no,” I stammered out, trying to keep my cool as best as possible. “No relation. They’re new in town, from what I hear.”

“Guess they’re planning on staying awhile; they’ve ordered enough glass to retrofit a whole building. But if they’re not your clan, then they’ll be paying full price for it.” Zane wandered off, seemingly unaware of the sudden cloud of worry that had formed over my head. Perhaps it was because, as a vampire, the blood didn’t rush from my face in times of terror.

“You okay?” Asha asked as we began exiting once again, now with bottles in hand. “You seemed to go pretty stiff when he mentioned the other vampires.”

“I’ll be all right,” I said, probably with more hope than I felt. It had been

so long since the Turvas came up that I'd managed to forget about them, but one mention from Zane brought it all rushing back. What's worse, they were apparently setting up shop, so the moving-in process was going smoothly.

"Let me know if you need a lawyer," Asha offered. "But maybe wait a few days first. After this, I'm taking a long weekend."

"Not a bad idea," I agreed. We parted at the door, she heading to her sedan and me to the truck where Bubba and Amy were already waiting.

I climbed in and rested my head against the window, watching the moon sink slowly from the sky. How long had it been stuck there, while we scrambled about inside the mansion to try and broker a peace between two siblings? I could feel the familiar fuzziness at the edge of my thoughts that came when I'd stayed awake for too long. Maybe Asha was on the right track. I couldn't afford to take a whole vacation, but this time when the sun rose, perhaps I'd let sleep claim me. One day of solid, uninterrupted rest.

It wasn't much of a splurge, but by God, I'd earned it.

# A Lawyer in the Manor

## 1.

“They want a meeting.”

Those words had hung heavy in my mind since Richard uttered them, not three seconds into a phone call with me. While details had followed, I’d barely listened, as such words weren’t truly necessary. There was only one “they” who would seek a meeting with me through Richard, only one group that would put such gravity in his voice. The House of Turva, Winslow’s newest vampire clan, was finally beginning to move. What that meant for me was anyone’s guess, as they’d done little interacting beyond the basics of making peace. My only way to find out if they were friend, foe, or apathetic neighbor was to take the meeting.

Of course, that didn’t mean I had to be stupid about how I did it. My car eased into the parking lot in front of Charlotte Manor, a new night’s stars twinkling overhead. A massive Jeep that looked like it had been driven over straight from war was already parked nearby, and was obviously Richard’s ride. I couldn’t begrudge him the extra room; there was no sedan on the market that had the space to comfortably contain a man of his size. Pausing to lock my doors and double check that I had, in fact, remembered my briefcase, I headed up the front steps, where Charlotte was already waiting for me.

I realize that this can be a bit confusing, so allow me a moment to clarify the difference between Charlotte and Charlotte Manor. Charlotte Manor is the proper, given name of the structure that served as half B&B, half rented-out home to a pair of agents. Charlotte, on the other hand, was the house’s personality, its physical representation that usually took the form of a young woman who favored dresses so large and complex it was rare to see them outside of a period play. Neil had once said it best: Charlotte was the house’s avatar, the way it interacted with us.

That was who was waiting for me as I stepped onto the porch. She offered me a glass of wine—materializing food and drink was one of her less spectacular but more useful abilities—which I had to refuse.

“Working tonight,” I informed her. “Wouldn’t be appropriate.”

“Really? Because the big guy inside has already downed five glasses of ale. And my mugs are well above normal pint size.” There was a touch of pride in Charlotte’s voice; she took great satisfaction in her hospitality skills.

“Richard isn’t the one who needs to worry.”

“You wouldn’t know that from the way he’s pacing about,” Charlotte replied. “When are the other guests arriving?”

I headed for the door, and she followed along beside me, matching my steps perfectly. “Soon. We set it for two hours after sunset, but there’s no guarantee they won’t be early. Richard briefed you on what to do?”

“He’s been here for hours; he won’t shut up about it.” Charlotte made a small gesture with her hand and the front door opened to reveal another, identical Charlotte waiting patiently. “I’m supposed to look like the little old lady and wait staff, do nothing to draw attention, and keep up the normal appearances. Unless they try anything.”

This was why I’d chosen Charlotte Manor as the meeting spot between myself and the Turva clan. If things took a turn for the aggressive, Charlotte could easily keep them captive long enough for me to escape. She was technically built to keep people out more than in, so holding a pair of vampires indefinitely would be a tall order even for her, but she could buy me time. That would be enough.

“Yes, but wait for my signal,” I reminded her. “Let’s not make a move unless it’s necessary.”

Whatever Charlotte would have said next was drowned out by the stampeding footsteps of Richard Alderson barreling down the front hall. No matter how times I met the man, it was impossible not to be taken aback by his size. He was enormous, tall enough to make NBA players feel threatened, and his wide body was completely packed with muscle. Add in the shaggy blond hair and teeth that were just a little too white and sharp, and I considered it one of my greatest personal accomplishments not to have collapsed in fear the first time we met. Then again, he’d been in leader mode then, which was far more outwardly intimidating than the man behind the curtain.

“Fred, I’m sorry. I tried to stall this for as long as I could.”

The apology didn’t surprise me; Richard had been giving them ever since he dropped the bomb that a meeting was formally requested. Evidently, he’d kept a lot of people between himself and the new vampires, ducking them at every chance for a lot of reasons. However, the thing about parahumans is that, while they might have little respect for the rules of humanity, they would, at least publicly, adhere to the letter of their own laws and treaties. A formal request sent through the proper channels was impossible to ignore without causing trouble, even for someone of Richard’s status.

“I’ve told you, it’s fine. If they wanted to talk with me, it was going to happen sooner or later. At least this way, we control the terms,” I assured him. “Maybe they just want me to go over their books.”

“Seems like the sort of thing an e-mail could convey. You’re never shy about handing out those business cards.” This voice belonged to neither me, Richard, nor Charlotte. Instead, it came from the blonde woman currently descending the stairs. For a moment, I almost didn’t recognize my own

girlfriend.

Krystal's usually free-flowing hair was pulled tight into a ponytail, a set of ill-fitting glasses perched on the bridge of her nose and an oversized sweatshirt swallowing up her torso. While her jeans were the same as usual, she'd traded her standard boots for a set of sensible sneakers. There was also something off about her face, though I had to really stare to realize that, while she seemed to be wearing less makeup than usual, she was actually wearing more. She'd used it to contour her features and somehow appear less striking than normal. All of this was enhanced by the way she moved, meticulously, with a slight slouch in her spine and her head always tilted a touch downward. Normal Krystal barreled through a room like a panther with the excitement of a Labrador. This version inched along as though she wasn't even sure she wanted to be there.

"That's a . . . new look." I racked my mind for something positive to say. It was obvious she was trying to dull herself down, but not even I was so inexperienced at love that I would say such a thing without prompting. There's being willing to meet with potentially aggressive vampires, and then there's just plain suicidal.

"You like? I saw the latest fashions from Milan and just had to get my hands on it." She stuck her tongue out and made a sound not unlike someone passing gas, and, for a moment, I could see the real Krystal shining through, clothes and makeup be damned. "There's no way I'm letting you take this meeting without me nearby, but I didn't want to raise too much suspicion."

"Do you think they'd assume you were an agent just from your normal style of dress?" I asked.

"Doubtful, but the more I blend into the background, the better," she replied. "And plus, if it comes out that I'm your lady, no one will bat an eye."

"You think they would normally?" I looked to Richard and Charlotte, both of whom had suddenly found things on the wall and ceiling to stare at with unwavering interest.

Krystal released her false walk, bounding the rest of the way down the stairs and over to me. "Freddy, I love you dearly, you know that. But the people who don't know you as well as we do might think you come off a little . . . dull. I just thought this version of me might be easier to swallow for those who make the wrong assumptions about you."

"Well then, I have to say you've failed." Before she could reply, I leaned forward and kissed her, a very rare show of public affection spurred on by a combination of gratitude and fear. "You're still much too lovely for the likes of me. I'm afraid there is just no amount of makeup or frumpy clothing that will ever conceal how beautiful you are."

It was one of the precious few times in our relationship that I'd managed to be the one to take her by surprise, and I savored the slight blush in her

cheeks as she hurriedly recovered.

“After a line like that, I’m damn sure not letting you get killed,” Krystal said at last. “Richard, tell me you’ve got a plan.”

Having finished staring at the wall, Richard swung back around and led us to the dining room. “The Turvas contacted me, saying they wanted to discuss business with Fred. I told them to call him themselves, he’s not hard to find, and they countered by saying it was business outside the normal spectrum and that they’d greatly appreciate an introduction. A gesture of friendship, they called it.”

The nerves faded from Richard’s voice, replaced by something far heavier. The man had an entire clan that depended on him, and he took that job seriously. While many would have seen it as a license to do as they pleased, Richard understood it was a duty, a burden, one he had to be strong enough to bear.

“Present company excluded, vampires can be a real pain in the ass to deal with. Their treaties give them a lot of freedom when it comes to hunting, as long they don’t kill their victims, and since therians in human form are allegedly hard to distinguish from regular mortals, it’s hard to go after them for taking blood from my people. So far, the Turvas have been playing very nice, keeping a wide berth from any parahumans and being discreet in their feeding. If I can, I’d prefer to have them keep that up. Violence would come with costs to both our sides, ones I don’t want to pay.”

“Again, Richard, it’s fine. You couldn’t very well refuse such a simple request without reason,” I reminded him. “And it might be all around better that you didn’t. That could have betrayed that we’re friends. As far as the Turvas know, I’m just someone you hired to save you money on your taxes. The more mundanely they see me, the less reason they have to show fear or be interested.”

“Still doesn’t sit right in my gut.” Richard opened the door to the dining room, where Charlotte was already waiting. She was surrounded by waiters—all of them also her, just in another form—that were holding serving dishes waiting to be opened. The table was currently cleared off, except for two pairs of place settings on opposite sides.

“As requested, a fine meal is waiting to be served at your leisure,” Charlotte informed us.

“Wait, what?” This wasn’t part of the plan; it was supposed to be a quick meeting. I certainly didn’t want to spend a whole dinner with these people.

“My idea, Freddy,” Krystal said, walking calmly over to one of the place settings. “Give me your briefcase.”

I complied, and she set the case down in a chair before one of the settings. Wordlessly, she picked up the utensils and handed them to a waiter, where they vanished into thin air. Reaching into a compartment on her sweatshirt,



Krystal pulled out identical utensils, setting them down carefully in the same spots the original ones had been.

“A little bit of insurance, just in case,” she explained. “Having dinner justifies the place settings, and no vampire is afraid of a butter knife. But you aren’t going to be eating with the same tools as everyone else, Freddy. You’re going to have silver utensils. Specially made too, just like agent-issue tools, so that they won’t be easily detectable by scent.”

It was an odd kind of brilliant; silver was the ultimate double-edged sword in the parahuman world. The material hurt almost all of us, which made it both effective to use and dangerous to handle. As a result, very few parahumans messed with the stuff, and certainly none would think to suspect that a vampire’s utensils were made of it. Silver immunity was nigh unheard of among the undead.

“When, exactly, did you have silver duplicates of Charlotte’s utensils made?” Richard asked, bringing up an excellent point that I was a little ashamed about not noticing.

Krystal shrugged, barely visible through her oversized shirt. “Around the same time I moved in. Always pays to be prepared. I told her I was doing it, though she’s the one who gave me the molds.”

“Just be sure to pick those up when this is done.” Charlotte had moved several feet away from the table. As a being composed almost entirely of magic, silver was more painful for her than most parahumans. It meant a lot to me that she was tolerating it on her table.

“Agent’s honor,” Krystal promised. “And Freddy, I know I don’t really need to tell *you* this, but these are for defensive purposes only. Try to resist the urge to pretend you’re an action hero.”

“Somehow, I think I’ll find the self-control.” I hadn’t realized how on edge I was until I heard the squeal of tires from the parking lot. Evidently, I’d let my usual shutting out of the vampire senses lapse, because that noise was far too quiet to be heard with human ears. Still, I did appreciate the warning.

“Looks like our guests have arrived,” I told them. “Everybody into position.”

## 2.

I wasn't surprised to see Lillian as one of the vampires who'd come out to meet me, though I was taken a bit back by her choice of wearing a pantsuit, as I'd assumed the last time she'd worn one was solely out of deference to their meeting with therians. She hadn't really seemed like the type to embrace professional attire as habit, but I suppose I, of anyone, should have known better than to judge a book by its cover.

The man with her wore a lovely pinstriped number that I knew on sight had been hand-tailored. He was also one of the oldest-looking vampires I'd encountered, which, admittedly, was a sample size of three before him. A few wrinkles hung around his eyes, and his dark hair had gone silver in streaks along the side. His face was handsome, but approachable, the sort you'd find as a department head or neighbor that ran the HOA.

"Mr. Alderson, thank you for making the time to meet with us." He bowed to Richard, not very deeply, but enough to show respect. For his part, Richard had his game face on, which consisted of being stiff, detached, and more than a bit terrifying. Unless these two had been drinking some incredibly potent blood, Richard could probably take them apart by himself. Unfortunately, that would also cause quite the incident between vampires and therians, which is why he was around more for show and friendship than backup.

"And you must be Mr. Fletcher." The man turned to me, giving another bow. I rose from my seat and stuck out a hand. Bowing might be the way vampires did it, but accountants were taught the art of the handshake to show our respect.

"Yes, sir, Fredrick Fletcher of Fletcher Accounting Services."

He looked at my hand for a few moments before taking it and offering a firm shake. "I am Petre, of the House of Turva." The shake continued; he was waiting for something, though I had no idea what. It might have gone on forever if Lillian hadn't stepped forward.

"Fredrick, it is common courtesy to announce the name of your clan in meetings such as this."

"It is?" This time, I did bow, a little. I'd made the mistake, so it seemed like meeting him halfway on tradition was a good form of apology. "I'm terribly sorry. I don't have a clan, as far as I know."

"Your clan is your sire's clan, unless you've been cast out," Petre told me.

"My sire never taught me anything about that. He turned me and left me on my own. The only other time I saw him was when he beat me senseless and threatened to kill me." Both Petre and Lillian seemed to shrink back at

that news, the former finally allowing our handshake to come to an end.

“Then it is I who am sorry,” Petre said, quickly recovering himself. “The bond between a sire and their child is meant to be a sacred one. For you to have survived on your own, learning the way of the night without an instructor, is no small feat.”

“Well, movies helped a lot.” I appreciated the praise, but I really didn’t want them thinking more of me than was strictly necessary. “I knew to avoid silver and sunlight right off the bat, and since I didn’t plan on driving any stakes through my heart, that was already off the table.”

Petre regarded me with a long stare. There was a lot going on in those cool, pale blue eyes, most of which I was probably happier not knowing. “I suppose that is one benefit to our culture being absorbed and spread throughout the humans’ consciousness.”

“It’s nice to see you again, Fredrick,” Lillian butted in, offering a much needed respite from the intensity of Petre’s gaze. “And you’re not even hooked to a taxi this time. Makes you look more composed.”

“I appreciate your help that night,” I replied, choosing my words carefully. Anything that signified a debt between us could be dangerous, especially if this turned to negotiations. “You look well, yourself.”

“It’s only proper.” Lillian smiled like she knew something I didn’t, which was completely unnecessary. We were all keenly aware that she and Petre had things hidden up their sleeves, just as they no doubt assumed I had a few tricks, as well.

“If you’re done with introductions, can we get this moving? I have other tasks to see to tonight.” Richard’s voice was edging on an animal’s growl, his inner lion poking through. Rough as his tone was, I was glad for it, since it helped to keep things speeding along.

We all took our seats at the table as the kitchen door opened and a waiter breezed in, carrying a tray of crab cakes. Petre and Lillian both looked momentarily distressed by the appearance of staff, so I spat my words out as quickly as I could.

“It’s fine, this whole place is parahuman friendly,” I told them. “There’s a presence in the house, so everyone here is already in on the secret. We can speak freely.”

“What an intriguing establishment.” Petre watched the waiters closely, but Charlotte was doubling down on her avatar. Every step they made squeaked, each motion was clumsy enough to be human, and she was even replicating the sound of blood pumping through a heart. Unless either of the vampires tried to take a bite, they’d have no idea their waiter wasn’t real. “How ever did you find such a place?”

“I was called in to help settle some ownership issues and account discrepancies. Things went well, so they put my services on retainer.” Now

that the conversation was finally steering toward business, I jumped on the opportunity to pop open my briefcase and pull out two identical sheets of paper.

“Since Richard called me here for a meeting, I took the liberty of putting together some information about exactly which services I offer, and the general estimations of hours needed for each task. As you’ll note, I have different projections for digital records versus physical ones, since that adds a lot of time, but the hourly rate stays consistent throughout.”

Petre and Lillian both examined their documents, looking them over dutifully despite the fact that I doubted either of them had needed such services in a very long time. As I’ve said before, parahumans are not the best at record-keeping in any capacity. Finally, Petre lowered his back to the table.

“You have quite the list of services, Mr. Fletcher. It’s not often one sees a member of our species take on such . . . thankless tasks. Those who are turned tend to lean toward grander spectacles, using their new abilities to reach heights unattainable by mortality.”

“I like to think I did the same. After all, becoming a vampire was what gave me the push to start my own company.” My smile was placid, as though I hadn’t even noticed that he’d tried to tactfully call me boring. If Petre thought I was going to take offense to something like that, he clearly hadn’t done much homework.

“Indeed.” His fingers ran along the edge of the page, crinkling it ever so slightly as it rested on the wooden surface of the table. “May I ask why you wished to share this with us? Perhaps you were looking for insight on what options need to be added?”

“A generous offer, but I’ve got it well in hand. I was showing you the price list because I have a policy of being upfront on cost with all potential clients. You called the meeting, so there’s obviously something you’re looking to book an accountant for, but it’s important to me that you have a fair sense of the price going in. All part of running an upstanding business.”

While that truly was my philosophy when meeting new clients, the odds of that being applicable here were slim. I’d decided that my best bet for making it through this encounter was to play it dumb. As an abandoned vampire with no clan and minimal knowledge of vampire society, it took very little acting to pull off. My hope was that if I could convince them I was a non-threat, that I was just an undead guy who was good with numbers, they’d see there was nothing to gain from dealing with me. Except maybe a reliable person to call during tax season.

“The honesty is appreciated,” Petre replied. “However, we did not call this meeting to request your accounting services. Rather, I requested it to get to know you on a more informal level. There are very few vampires in the area; Quinn, the traitor, made it quite inhospitable for any that tried to make a home

here. I was surprised to learn that he'd tolerated the presence of another. Tell me, was he kept at bay by the need for your services?"

"No." The word came out with an edge I was only mildly aware of, prickling my tongue as it fell away. "No, it's safe to say Quinn did anything but leave me alone. But I already told you that my sire abandoned me."

Now *that* got a reaction. Petre's lip twitched for the barest of moments, a snarl he forcibly kept from forming. "I wish I could say I was surprised that even he would do such a thing, but the truth is that among Quinn's crimes, such an action is hardly notable. It is still awful, though, and I'm sorry you had to endure it. Trust me when I say there is no love lost between the House of Turva and Quinn, the traitor."

"Nor do I hold any affection for my sire." That part required no fudging whatsoever. Quinn had tried to kill me, along with my friends. I never considered myself a hateful person, but I wished all the ill the world could muster on the man who turned me.

"Quinn is a real dick," Lillian chimed in. "And I don't think anyone is sad that he's gone into hiding. But tell us, Fredrick, how did you survive? You mentioned he threatened to kill you, and Quinn had a reputation for making good on such promises."

"I was lucky," I told her, no shame in my voice at the admittance. "Before he could get to me, Quinn picked a fight with someone else. An agent. That went about the way you'd expect it to, and as far as I know, he's been running ever since."

Petre made a noise halfway between a harrumph and snort. "*Agents*. They do have their uses, I suppose. Quinn was always more ambitious than smart. I can't say I'm shocked that his brashness finally caught up with him."

I couldn't think of anything to say that would close the topic without inviting further questions, so instead, I picked up my silver fork and scooped out a piece of the crab cake cooling before me. Like everything Charlotte made, it was scrumptious. It took me three more bites before I noticed that Lillian and Petre were watching me eat.

"Did you need a lemon sauce?" I asked.

"We do not partake in the food of humans." Petre didn't even try to mask the disdain in his voice. Lillian nodded in agreement, though I noticed her eyes lingering on the crab cake in front of her. "Blood is the only delicacy a vampire need taste. It is the perfect, the ultimate, the unequivocal joy. Everything else is but ash in the mouth by comparison."

Carefully considering his point, I waited a few moments more, then took another bite. Nope, definitely not ash. "Blood is quite delicious, but I've yet to lose my taste for the more familiar dishes of life. Maybe it's something that comes with time."

Petre kept looking at me as I scooped up another few morsels before

finally responding. "Perhaps so. It is not entirely your fault for not knowing such truths, either. As an Abandoned, there was no one to teach you the proper ways of our kind."

"All things considered, I think I got off lucky being abandoned, if my other option was being taught by Quinn," I pointed out.

"Did you really call this damn meeting just for small talk?" Richard, who had been busying himself tucking away his own crab cake with enormous bites, dropped his fork to the empty plate below with a loud clatter. "I've got better things to do than listen to the vampires in town get to know some guy who does my taxes. Petre, if you pulled me into a useless meeting as an attempted show of power, I should warn you now that I won't take it well."

The whole room seemed to grow still at Richard's words. What he'd said was no idle threat. Power and authority were so important they verged on holy in the parahuman world, even more so with therians. A man in Richard's position couldn't afford to let himself be made an errand boy by some new vampires in town. Asking for a favor was one thing. Asking for a pointless favor to show they could make him do it was something different altogether. Depending on Petre's answer, they might soon have much more serious matters to deal with than some lowly accountant in their town.

"Our apologies, Mr. Alderson," Lillian said at last. Her subdued tone was a pleasant contrast to Petre's haughty nature; it was no wonder he kept her around. "Petre merely wished to get to know Fredrick before broaching our true business. Such is the traditional method to show respect and build a relationship. By all means, please feel free to leave if you like. We will certainly take no offense. Your gesture has been fulfilled merely by making the introduction."

Fear boiled in my stomach, tossing the crab cake to-and-fro. I knew Richard wouldn't want to leave me, but what if he couldn't think of a way to stay nearby without betraying that he saw me as more than a contracted employee? Giving away our friendship meant handing these people a bit of information, and I already knew that the less we gave them, the better.

"Much as I would like to, the fact remains that you asked me to make this meeting happen," Richard replied. "The accountant was barely ever in my service, but I did *have* to use him. It wouldn't look very well if I introduced you to one of my employees and then you went off and killed him. I have a reputation to uphold."

A bit hurtful, but it was hard to argue with the route Richard had taken. Making it about him and his reputation gave him adequate cause to stay nearby as a witness, without letting on that we were friends. If anything, Richard sounded like he detested me, which, I suppose, did fit the usual vampire-therian dynamic. Dealing with Petre and Lillian, I was beginning to think that perhaps I really had gotten a blessing in disguise by not knowing

my sire for long. It had allowed me to shape my own relationships with other parahumans, rather than having them dictated to me.

“Very well, then. In respect to Mr. Alderson, we will move past the customary small talk, assuming that is all right with you, Mr. Fletcher,” Petre said. I nodded my agreement, and he immediately continued.

“I called this meeting because I wished to know more about the vampire who survived in the same town that Quinn, the traitor, oversaw. The House of Turva needed to assess if you managed such a feat by wit or might. Now, I see that you had no hand in it. You were simply one of Quinn’s experiments. What he intended for you, we may never know, but it seems you’ve made something of your life regardless. Since I do not deem you to be a threat, my clan has authorized me to make a gesture of friendship.”

“That’s appreciated, but unnecessary,” I said, doing my best to head off this line of talk. One thing I’d learned from watching Richard, these sorts of gestures never came without strings. Whatever they offered, it would make me indebted to them, and that was the last place I wanted to be.

“Mr. Fletcher, as an Abandoned, I understand you might not know this, but to refuse a gesture of friendship is akin to declaring us your enemy.” Petre didn’t make it sound like a threat, which was exactly what told me how serious it was. When people moved past the bluster, it meant they weren’t worried about your reaction. Things just were what they were.

“Oh? Then I do ask that you please forgive me. As you said, I have not been properly educated.” I’d been backed into a corner; my only hope was that it would be something small and easily repaid.

“It is to be expected from an Abandoned,” Petre replied. “As I was saying, the House of Turva wishes to make a gesture of friendship. After some inquiring, we heard that you were looking for a helper to swell the ranks of your growing company. Thus, it is my pleasure to present to you the newest employee of Fletcher Accounting Services.”

He gracefully opened his hand, gesturing to Lillian, who gave me a small wave paired with a wide smile.

“Looks like you’re my new boss, Fredrick.”

### 3.

“I don’t like her.” Krystal didn’t bother keeping her voice low; Charlotte could block the sound between walls so well that not even vampire ears managed to hear through them. My girlfriend was leaning back in her chair, arms crossed and a scowl etched into her face. “A little too nice, a little too charming. And what’s with that ‘Fredrick’ shit? Getting pretty familiar pretty fast, if you ask me.”

“Well, that *is* my actual name,” I tried to point out, but the glare I received shut me down quickly.

“Missing the point, Freddy.”

Dinner had wrapped up not long after Petre dropped the bomb named Lillian on me; he’d excused himself and drove off, leaving his fellow vampire behind. Under the pretense of handling some private business regarding his books, Richard and I had left Lillian in the dining room to have a quick consultation with Krystal. I’d hoped she could shed some insight on how to deal with the situation, but her ideas were . . . less than productive.

“I’m just saying, accidents happen all the time, and it’s not like Freddy doesn’t have a reputation for ending up in trouble. Maybe he goes on a call that runs a little long, and she gets stuck out in the sunlight while he barely survives.”

“I know you’re kidding, but just that joke made my blood pressure go up,” Richard told her. “Petre is the number two in that clan, and he showed up to personally deliver Lillian as a token of friendship. If anything happens to her that smells even remotely suspicious, I’m going to have a ton of trouble on my hands.”

“Think the Turva clan will get violent?” I asked.

“Worse. They’ll drag me through meeting after meeting in diplomatic hearings.” Richard shuddered, which made the chair he was seated on wobble violently. “I can handle a brawl or two, and my people vastly outnumber theirs. But when they invoke the treaties and pull me into that mind-numbing diplomatic bullshit, that’s the real torture.”

Krystal snorted, then looked up to the ceiling. “Charlotte, is she doing anything weird? Anything we could use as grounds for her being here under malicious intent?”

“She is sitting quietly at the dinner table, eating the cold crab cake left in front of her.” Charlotte appeared between me and the doorway, wearing her usual antique dress. While Krystal and Richard seemed disappointed by the news, I found it a bit intriguing. It seemed Lillian didn’t entirely agree with



the Turvas' stance on blood being the only acceptable food for vampires to touch. Maybe there were other things they didn't see eye-to-eye on, as well.

"Charlotte, please book a room for Lillian," I instructed.

"Excuse me?" Krystal whipped her head around so fast that the fake glasses ended up cockeyed on her head.

"Like it or not, we're stuck with her for now," I explained. "Petre drove off in the car they came in, so I get the feeling she's not heading home anytime soon. I don't want to bring her to my apartment, so getting a room here is the best place to house her. Plus, if she *does* do anything suspicious, Charlotte will know about it and give us warning. We just have to make sure to tell Arch before he gets back from whatever assignment he's on; I doubt it would do well for her to realize she's bunking with agents."

"I can send a message to him," Krystal said. "And while I'm not crazy about sharing a house with that girl, I like it a lot better than having her try to crash with you. Not that I don't trust you, Freddy, but it would probably get awkward. This situation has "honeypot" written all over it."

Despite what you may expect, that term did not go over my head. I had taken in more than enough cinema about spies and subterfuge to know that a honeypot was when a covert operative attempted to seduce a target in order to gain information or trust. Unfortunately, knowing what Krystal meant just made it all the more awkward, as I considered that possibility for why Lillian was being handed to me as an assistant. It was a small mercy that vampires couldn't blush; I suspect I would have ended up on the receiving end of Krystal's wrath if my cheeks had suddenly gone red.

"Her plans are irrelevant. I intend to keep this relationship as detached and professional as I can manage." Krystal still looked a bit wary, though my words seemed to somewhat mollify her. "If anything, this might be a blessing in disguise. We all agree that she's most likely here as a spy, but knowing that means that we can control what she sees. After a week or so of working on accounts and doing filings, she'll realize that I truly am nothing more than an accountant, and can report her findings up the chain of command. I'll bore the House of Turva out of any interest in me."

Richard, Krystal, and Charlotte all exchanged a look. It was a brief one, but volumes seemed to pass between them in the span of that glance. After a moment, Richard rose from his chair to address me. "I'm not saying that's a bad idea, because it's not. But . . . come on, Fred. You have to know as well as we do that dealing with parahumans means a certain element of the unexpected. It wasn't even a couple of weeks ago you were trapped inside a pocket dimension with a pair of mages."

"Those . . . *incidents*, while unavoidable, happen few and far between," I replied. "How long do we really expect Lillian to hang in with me doing accounting work? A week, maybe two or three, at the most? Even if we do hit

a chaotic incident, at most she'll see that the services come with a certain amount of risk, but that doesn't make me into a threat."

"No, but she might realize you're the vampire all those rumors are about." Krystal looked worried, which was all the stranger to see in her frumpy get-up. "They are still looking for that guy, too. The exploits got so exaggerated by the rumor mill that no one suspects it's you; however, if that vamp gets to see up close and personal what your job entails, she might put two and two together."

"So I stick to simple, easy accounts with minimal chance of things going nuts," I replied. "I think I've even still got some human clients I can check in on. This can work; we just have to bore her into submission."

"It's a better idea than refusing the offer and starting a feud with the House of Turva," Richard agreed. "Quinn really screwed you good, Fred. If you were actually part of a clan, they could intercede for you, keep others like the Turvas from just deciding that you were going to hire one of their people."

"From what I've seen, I actually think I prefer being on my own," I told him.

"Hey now, these people might be dicks, but there's something to be said for clans and tribes." Richard stood a little taller, which caused his sizable head to scrape against the bottom of the bedroom ceiling. "A lot of the ones who get turned lose their old lives, their old families, and end up alone in the world. Clans and tribes give them new people to turn to, and help in rebuilding their suddenly broken worlds. When done right, we're something of a surrogate family, and a lot of people need that."

"My apologies, Richard. I know how deeply you care for your people, and maybe if I'd been turned into a therian, things would be different. I just meant that, based on the vampires I've encountered, I think I'm a lot happier with how being abandoned turned out."

"And I think we can all agree that Fred has done an oddly good job at constructing his own makeshift family," Krystal added.

"Just to let you all know, Lillian has finished her food and is currently sitting at the table, looking bored," Charlotte reported. "Shall I bring her the next course?"

"No, we should probably head back to the table, anyway." I looked over at Richard, who'd ducked back down after bumping his head on the ceiling. "Will you be joining us?"

"Officially, I still need to make sure she isn't going to kill you," Richard replied. "Unofficially, if you think for one hot second I'm skipping out on Charlotte's cooking, you've got another thing coming."

I could hardly fault the man there, but as we headed for the door, I noticed we weren't alone. Krystal had fallen in behind us, only a few steps behind Richard, whose bulk blocked out the door frame.

“Um, Krystal? What are you doing?”

“Isn’t it obvious? Since the official meeting is over, the other tenant in Charlotte Manor is going to head down and get some food.” She adjusted her glasses and tugged on the oversized sweatshirt. “Besides, if Lillian is going to be crashing here, then she should probably meet your girlfriend sooner rather than later. If she asks, my place is being fumigated and that’s why I’m living in a B&B.”

“A supposedly haunted B&B,” I pointed out. “And dating a vampire. Crap. What sort of parahuman are we going to say you are?”

“My grandparents were a quarter Fey.” There was no hesitation in her explanation; clearly, Krystal had already thought this story through. “Still connected enough to the parahuman world that I’d have been raised around it, but my blood is so diluted that there’s no longer much sign of magic. While I’d like to claim I’m a full human who found out about the world by chance, it’s just too risky without knowing what she’s been feeding on. If it’s something that can perceive magic, then I’m sure to trip her senses, so putting in a little Fey ancestry will cover my ass on that front.”

That was news to me; I didn’t realize there were creatures out there that could sense Krystal’s true nature. It really shouldn’t have been, though. I’d learned time after time that the parahuman world was bigger and more complex than I could imagine. There were bound to be all sorts of different creatures with various talents out there, almost all of which a vampire could copy abilities from. That’s what made us so dangerous, and so feared, even among other parahumans. Every time I met a new client, they were always a bit wary of me, never quite sure what I was capable of, and if I was looking at them as a source of income, or blood.

We made our way back down the hall, and Krystal grabbed my hand just outside the dining room door. She said nothing, though. With the doorway open, not even Charlotte could muffle the words away from Lillian’s hearing. Instead, she just held me there as we watched Richard make his way into the dining room and roughly greet Lillian. It occurred to me for the first time that as long as my new employee was around, we were going to have to keep up the facade of Richard, of pretty much all my friends, not caring for me. The ruse would be for my protection, as I couldn’t very well be marked as best buddies with a therian, or a mage, or a wielder of a weapon of destiny. All the same, even the idea of it felt lonely, and I found myself hoping Lillian would give up quickly so that things could get back to normal.

A tight squeeze on my hand reminded me that Krystal was still there, that she’d found a way to stay with me even with Lillian hovering around us. I felt a surge of love and gratitude for her, leaning in for a quick kiss while we were momentarily alone. She reciprocated warmly, then pulled away and carefully mouthed a single soundless word.

“Showtime.”

With that, Krystal slouched her way into the dining room and let out a squeal of mock surprise. “Oh my goodness, Freddy didn’t mention that his guests were still here. I’m so sorry to interrupt your dinner.”

Awkward, deferential, and apologetic; this version of Krystal was about as far from the real one as she could get. Whether I liked it or not, the pageant had begun.

## 4.

“Are you sure I can’t come along?” Albert stood in the doorway as I packed up my computer bag for the night ahead. Having managed to make it through dinner without anyone getting killed, I’d retired back to my apartment and spent the entire day working out a plan for the coming week. I’d gone through all my accounts, choosing the safest, least likely jobs to turn into anything exciting. Lillian was going to accompany me on boring client visits and assessments until she either quit or I ran out of dull situations to shove her in.

By this point, you’re no doubt wondering why I didn’t just stick my unwanted employee in front of a mound of paperwork and be done with her. The idea did occur to me—it was an obvious solution to the problem—however, it came with a serious drawback: if I let her handle any aspect of the real accounting, I’d be trusting her with my clients’ confidential information. Since I didn’t even trust her to know things about me, I certainly wasn’t going to allow her access to any of my clients’ private fiscal records. Better to drag her around town and risk my own exposure than allow her clan to get its hooks into the people who trusted me.

“No, Albert. I’m afraid it’s too dangerous. Besides, I need you handling the more delicate work while I’m saddled with Lillian.” Much as I might have enjoyed Albert’s company, he was too high profile to bring along. The Blade of the Unlikely Champion took serious issue with being left behind, and Albert always seemed out of sorts when it wasn’t close by, but one look at the ornate weapon and she might be able to figure out that he was the town’s resident destiny-weapon wielder. And I really was leaning on him to handle a fair amount of tasks while I was busy. Parahumans didn’t often go in for digital delivery, and there were several clients expecting contracts, budget projections, and filing receipts to be delivered in the very near future. Some of those, Lillian and I would be handling, but all the ones with the potential to get more . . . exciting . . . had to be entrusted to Albert. Neil would also be tagging along, in case he needed backup.

“You can count on me, boss.” Albert saluted, then lowered his hand slowly as his cheerful expression became tinged with concern. “Is this lady really that dangerous?”

“She’s probably stronger than me, whatever little that says, but it’s not actually her I’m worried about,” I told him. “It’s her clan as a whole. If I can fall off their radar, be just an anomaly they know about but have no regard for, then that’s our optimum situation.”

“What’s the bad situation?” Albert asked.

I jammed the charging cord, portable Wi-Fi hotspot, and array of flash drives into the top pocket of my briefcase. “Honestly, I’m not sure. Maybe they try to drag me into their clan. Maybe they do a hostile takeover of the business. Maybe they . . . encourage me to leave town.” That actually wasn’t what I wanted to say, but there was no sense in worrying Albert with the least likely option. Even if I struck their interest, the chances of them deciding to kill me were slim. I hoped.

“All I know is that I’d prefer not to deal with them at all, if possible, and that’s what this week is about.”

“Got it.” Albert walked over to my desk, where I had neatly arranged all his assignments for the night. “But it’s too bad.”

“What do you mean?”

“You’ve been saying for a while that you needed more help. I just mean, it’s too bad that this Lillian lady can’t actually lend us a hand.” It was hard to argue with Albert as we both stared at the mound of assignments I’d set aside for him. Had Arch been in town, I’d have never been able to lay such a heavy burden on my assistant’s shoulders, but while the agent was gone, their training was on break. And he was right; the company did need to grow if I was going to keep up with demands. Just not like this.

“I’d far rather keep working overtime than accept any help the House of Turva wants to give,” I told him. “This business might not be much, but at least no one else can lay claim to it. That’s worth something to me.”

“To me, too,” Albert agreed, beginning to carefully scoop up his assignments and pile them into his backpack.

With my own accessories stowed, I said a quick goodbye, and then headed out into the crisp new night. The last of the sunset had only just fallen away, so the sky was still a bit lighter than usual. I did miss seeing the blue skies and sun, even if I was now able to glimpse them through enchanted windows. It wasn’t the same, though. I’d never really cared much for standing in sunlight during my living days; mostly, I’d considered it an inconvenience. Now, I’d have paid an obscene amount for the experience. But that was life; everything was a transaction. Nothing came free. Ageless existence and mystical powers were a comparatively small price to pay for giving up the ability to tan. I just still missed the sun, occasionally.

By the time I arrived at Charlotte Manor, Lillian was already waiting on the porch. She wore yet another pantsuit, probably delivered by someone in her clan, and had a large purse with a yellow legal pad sticking out the top. Before I could so much as pop open my door to greet her, she rushed forward, opening the passenger side of my hybrid and climbing gracefully in.

“Something wrong?” I asked.

“Just excited to get started on my first day of work.” Her smile was wide and infectious, but something in the way her eyes were twitching betrayed

Lillian's anxiety.

"You sure that's all? Did something happen? Did Krystal say anything?"

"Krystal? Hell no. That girl barely even speaks; she's quiet as a barn mouse." Lillian glanced back at Charlotte Manor through the window. "It's just . . . I don't want to sound ungrateful—I really appreciate you putting me up somewhere parahuman friendly and with such good food. But you mentioned that place has a presence, and the longer I've been staying there, the more I can feel it. It's hard to describe, like everywhere I go, I know someone is aware of my movements and what I'm doing. It's kind of unnerving."

"Sorry you had to go through that." I shifted the car into drive and began heading back toward Winslow's proper city area. It was probably of note that she could tell Charlotte was paying special attention to her; it meant her senses were either exceptional or she'd been dining on something with high awareness. Either way, I'd have to ask the house to be more discreet in keeping watch. "When we get back, I'll have a sit down with the presence; see if I can get it to offer you a little breathing room. We've had dealings before, so I should be able to talk it into backing off."

"I would greatly appreciate that." Lillian leaned back in the seat, seeming to finally relax now that the manor was fading into the rear view mirror. "So, what's on the docket for my first day on the job?"

"Listening," I told her. "And taking notes. Right now, you don't have any of the training or certifications to actually do accounting work, so I'm going to teach you the customer service portion of the job. In a normal firm, there are reps to deal with most of that, but this is a small operation, so every employee has to be able to handle multiple jobs."

"Can do," Lillian replied. "I like to think I've got a way with people. I used to get compliments on my bedside manner, way back when I had a heartbeat."

"You were a doctor?" I asked.

Lillian chuckled, hard laughter tainted with something darker than mirth. "A nurse. They didn't let women be doctors back then. No matter how much we might have wanted it."

I looked at Lillian once more, realizing for the first time just how great the difference in our ages was. I didn't know much about the history of physicians—the best I could recall was that the first female doctor had been sometime in the mid-eighteen hundreds, which put Lillian's human life somewhere before that. She was at least a hundred and fifty years old, yet she looked not a day past twenty-five. As someone who was undead, you might have expected me to be more prepared for these things, but there is a huge gap between knowing you'll live without aging and actually confronting it while driving toward a highway.

“Sorry to hear that,” I said finally, realizing I’d let the silence drag on a little too long. “Did you try going back into the field? Times have certainly changed since . . . whenever you were turned.” I tried to steer around the subject of when exactly she was made into a vampire. Part of it was out of politeness, and the rest was because I couldn’t shake the old adage of never asking a woman for her age from my head. I didn’t know if it applied to the undead, but this was not the occasion to find out.

“Times have changed out here, but some clans are a little more stuck in their ways.” Her eyes went wide at that, and she began speaking again so quickly she nearly stumbled over her words. “I mean, I’ve been busy helping my people. Not even the House of Turva runs itself. We all do our part to protect and watch over each other. It’s truly rewarding, knowing that my work helps my family.”

“And what kind of work might that be?” I asked. “I didn’t get a resume from you, so it might help to know your strengths and weaknesses when deciding how to train you.”

“Let’s just say I’m a quick learner, and I’ve been around long enough to do almost every sort of job you can picture. Although, accounting will be a new one for me,” Lillian admitted.

“Maybe that’s why they lent you out. They want someone on hand who can balance the books.” I carefully pulled through a green light and onto the ramp for the highway. Much as I loved Charlotte Manor, it was out in the boonies of Winslow and required more of a commute than I generally preferred.

“I’m not ‘lent out,’ Fredrick. I work for you now. No one is going to call me back and leave you high and dry. My clan takes its gestures of friendship seriously.” She patted her legal pad gently. “You don’t have to worry; I’m in for the long haul.”

“How lovely to hear.” I did my best to keep some cheer in my tone as I accelerated toward the city, hoping against hope that Lillian was lying her ass off.



## 5.

The first few appointments went as well as I'd hoped, if not better. I introduced Lillian as my trainee to the clients, then got right to business. The curtness wasn't malicious; I simply didn't want her to have any chance to let them know about her affiliation with the House of Turva. Presumed alliances could be problematic down the line, and I liked to keep my business meetings on track. After all, the client was paying for my time, so the discussion should be centered around their needs. With two drop-offs and one potential client meeting under my belt, I began to feel more confident as I drove us out of downtown Winslow to the pleasant housing area where my next appointment was waiting.

This one was to be the softest of softballs, as I was supposed to meet with Amy to do a quarterly update on her supply receipts. We went through her logs, marking which materials were for jobs and which were for personal use or testing so that everything could be written off properly come tax time. It didn't really need to be done quarterly, but that was about as long as we could manage without Amy forgetting and tossing the receipts out or setting them on fire. While the actual meeting hadn't been due for another few weeks, I moved it up especially for my new employee's first night. The whole task was glorified inventory work; dull, methodical, and perfect to bore Lillian out of her skull.

We pulled into the driveway of Amy's modest, quaint-looking home. She lived with ample space and fences between her house and the neighbors, and none of them were aware that she had a top-end alchemical laboratory tucked away in the rear of the property. From the front, it appeared to be a totally normal, somewhat unremarkable dwelling.

Except, that was, for the frantic woman darting toward my car. Amy's face was smeared with soot, and her hair was flying in all directions. She began waving at me, then noticed the passenger staring in aghast confusion and quickly tried to tone down her panic. That, in itself, was worrying enough; Amy was usually on so many self-crafted potions that she tended to be the mellowest person I knew. If she was panicking, something must have really gone awry.

"Hey there, Fred," Amy said as I opened the door and climbed from the car. "So great to see you, really looking forward to the meeting, just one small thing that maybe we can chat about first? In private?"

As she finished speaking, the sound of something crashing behind the house rang through the yard.

“Now,” Amy added, motioning for me to follow.

“Um . . . Lillian, the client has some confidential information to discuss. Please wait in the car, and do your best not to listen,” I said. To her credit, Lillian shut the door and turned on the radio without a word of disagreement, which was a small comfort as Amy began dragging me around to the back of her house.

We’d just turned the corner when she dug through her pockets, pulled out a small blue vial, and threw it to the ground. The air seemed to warp around us, as if we were standing on the inside of a bubble.

“That should block her from eavesdropping,” Amy said. “Soooo, we may have a bit of a problem.”

“You don’t say,” I replied, offering her a handkerchief to wipe the soot from her face.

“I know it’s not the best timing, but since you weren’t coming by until late, I figured I had a little window of time to get some work done tonight,” Amy explained, twisting the handkerchief around in knots on her fingers, the soot remaining uncleaned. “And Bubba has been up my ass about the enlarging potion, so when I finally had a breakthrough, I wanted to—”

“Hang on,” I interrupted. “What’s this about Bubba and a potion? He doesn’t touch anything stronger than beer.”

“This wasn’t the recreational stuff. He was looking for real alchemy, the kind with the power to create change. You know how sensitive he is about his size,” Amy said.

We all knew; it wasn’t something Bubba hid particularly well. Despite his pride in being a therian and a weresteed, Bubba had insecurity issues about the fact that he was considered something of a runt. While Richard easily dwarfed most other therians in his lion form, Bubba was at the opposite end of the spectrum—he got smaller when he shifted. In fact, he was so small that he wasn’t even technically a horse. He was a pony.

“He asked you to try and make a potion to fix that?”

“He’s been asking me for months. Ever since Gideon got captured,” Amy corrected, twisting the handkerchief even more. “And it’s been slow going. I can craft a potion to make him bigger, no problem, but it’s when you get into the permanent aspect that things become a lot more complicated. Anyway, I had an idea about distilling the essence from a Night Mare down and concentrating—”

“I’m sorry, a nightmare?” Much as I loathed to keep cutting Amy off, I wanted at least some clear idea of exactly what it was I was about to walk into.

Amy shook her head. “Two words. Legendary monster horse. Anyway, I got my supplies today, and decided to whip up a trial batch. I had Bubba take a drop, just a drop, to measure the effects. Good news: it sort of worked.

Better than I'd hoped, actually."

Another round of crashing, this time accompanied by what sounded like hoof beats, tore through the night. Apparently, Amy's bubble only kept sound in, not out. Or maybe it turned us into ghosts, for all I knew; it wasn't as though her experiments were predictable.

"Okay." I pinched the bridge of my nose, trying to think of how I was going to explain this to Lillian. Just a casualty of dealing with mages? Maybe that would sell; magic users did have a reputation for being unpredictable. "Okay, what do you need from me?"

"I put together a second potion to neutralize the first one before I ever gave it to him, just in case, but Bubba's not in his right mind. He's tearing about, making it impossible for me to get to the antidote. Plus, even if I grab it, I might need some help getting it in."

"So, keep him distracted, then?" I asked.

"Pretty much. And maybe hold him down if I can't get a syringe through his skin." With that, Amy began dragging me again, out of the bubble (which popped at her touch) and around the back of the house to where her lab stood. She yanked me along, through the door, and into a scene of complete chaos.

Tables, beakers, and general supplies were on the floor, mostly smashed. In the middle of the room, crushing a table beneath his sizable hooves, was what I could only assume was Bubba Emerson, though not like I'd ever seen him before. No longer was he a runt; instead, the top of his body stood above my shoulders, and while I'm far from the tallest in the world, I'm not short, either. His normal sandy coat had been replaced by one of ash-black, like a burned-out log, and orange flames flickered along his mane and hooves.

Well, that explained the soot on Amy's face. Sort of.

"What did you try to splice him with?"

"Really not the important issue right now," Amy replied.

"How about the fact that your lab looks completely smashed, and I'm guessing that includes the antidote, too," I countered.

"Please, you think I kept that in the upstairs lab?" Amy nodded to a small wooden door that I was positive hadn't been there the last time I visited her, or on any of the previous occasions. "I need to get past him and down to where the dangerous stuff is stored."

"Lovely. And what if he breaks through the walls?" I asked.

Amy shook her head. "Not possible. I've had enough experiments go wrong to know the value of sound construction. This house is warded up, down, and sideways. He's not busting out anytime soon."

I began stepping away from Amy—there was no sense in even trying this ridiculous idea unless I kept his attention solely on me. When I was across the room, I pressed my fingers to my lips and released the loudest whistle I could manage. Truthfully, it was pretty unimpressive, but evidently it was enough to

get the massive horse that was Bubba to look at me.

He stopped smashing up the table beneath his feet and turned to me, letting me see for the first time that his eyes were a dull red instead of a horse's usual glassy black. A snort came from his lips—mercifully not accompanied by a bout of flame—and his ears twitched as he stared at me.

“Hey, Bubba,” I said, keeping my voice as calm as was manageable in the face of a giant, burning horse. Amy began to slink silently toward the wooden door. “Do you know who I am? It's Fred. Your friend. The guy who stocks your favorite beer in his fridge.”

Another snort, but nothing aggressive. At least, not so far. Through my peripheral vision—I didn't dare risk a real glance—I saw Amy making progress, step by step, getting closer to the door. She was also getting closer to Bubba with every movement, so I kept talking, doing all I could to keep his attention rapt on me.

“It's okay. I'm here to help. We just need you to calm down a little. When this is over, we'll crack open a few beers and watch . . . whatever sport is on right now.” I'd like to blame panic for making me blank on which sport was in season at that moment in time, but truth be told, I couldn't have named it even without my friend being turned into a monster horse.

“We'll find something on. Maybe a nice action movie, or a western. Amy has the fancy cable; there's bound to be options.” At this point, I was mostly just saying whatever inane nonsense popped into my head. All that mattered was that I kept the sound going. As long as his attention was on me, Amy would be okay, and that was the important part. It almost worked, too. Unfortunately, Bubba wasn't the only one failing to pay attention to his environment.

The sound of crunching glass may as well have been a gunshot with how quiet the room was. Bubba let out a screeching whinny and reared onto his hind legs, twisting his head to see Amy, frozen in mid-sneak, her shoes lifting from the remains of a test tube. Faced with the split-second decision of how to handle the situation, she defaulted to the pair of options hardwired into every creature on the planet: fight or flight. Since her opponent was both an angry horse and a dear friend, Amy wisely chose the latter option, bolting the rest of the way to the wooden door before Bubba could get his bearings.

She barely made it, jerking the door open and slamming it shut an instant before Bubba careened into it. I expected the wood to buckle and splinter under the power of his charge, but it was Bubba who buckled instead, bouncing off the doorway like it was a block of steel. He shook his head, therian regeneration no doubt already patching up what little wounds he'd inflicted on himself, and then reared back again, trying to pound the entire wall with his hooves. It worked about as well as the charge, which was to say, not at all. Amy hadn't been kidding about the warding on her lab, and it was

all paying off at that moment.

Finally giving up on the wall, Bubba turned back around to face me. The red in his eyes didn't seem quite as dull this time around, and before I could muster so much as a comforting word, he charged. There are few things in life quite like watching a sizable steed partially covered in flames come barreling down at you while inside a closed room, and for those wondering, I would highly recommend against experiencing it. Especially if you don't have vampire reaction speeds.

I leapt to the side, scarcely getting out of Bubba's way in time, even with my superior dexterity. He was so damn fast now, his natural speed having been upgraded along with his size, that it was all I could do to avoid his stampeding bulk. Whatever remaining tables and supplies had been behind me weren't so lucky; I heard him crunching them into debris as he turned back around. Amy's lab was big, but not so large that it left me many places to go when facing off against a burning horse. Another change from Bubba, and again, I was able to jump to the side. He bounced off the wooden door again, coming away from the encounter with even more anger in his eyes.

This couldn't go on much longer; I was barely surviving each attack as it was. My eyes flicked to the doorway, but I immediately realized I couldn't escape. If Bubba followed me through an open door, I'd be setting him free on the world, which would make catching and curing him far more difficult. If he didn't, then I'd be leaving Amy as a sitting duck the minute she returned from her lab. I had to stick it out if we wanted to help Bubba, but I couldn't keep running around like I was.

As I dodged Bubba for the third time, nearly catching the leg of my slacks on fire, an idea finally struck me. He might be faster and stronger than me, but he wasn't as lithe. Stretching my fingers out, wishing dearly that I didn't keep my nails so trim, I leapt upward, all the way to Amy's ceiling. The moment I made contact, I jammed my hands through the soft drywall, groping about for a beam to hang on to. For a second, I thought all was lost as my hands closed around nothing, but then I felt the wonderful sensation of something solid and grabbed on for all I was worth. Using my abs to lift my legs, I pinned myself to the ceiling like a fly.

It wasn't a great long-term solution—I'd have to come down when Amy emerged so I could do distraction duty again—but for the moment, it meant I was safe from Bubba's assault. He trotted about beneath me, staring up at me with those relentless eyes.

"Sorry, buddy, I just needed time—" It was my turn to be interrupted, as Bubba leapt up from the ground, far higher than a normal horse could, on a direct track for me. There was no chance of dodging; I was far too taken by surprise.

All I could do was gasp in shock as Bubba's hooves smashed into me,

knocking me from the ceiling to the floor, where it would only be seconds until he started trampling me.

## 6.

Of all the things I was expecting to come next—stampeding hooves, lots of pain, perhaps even the smell of burning vampire flesh—what I did not count on was a blur in a pantsuit whipping through the doorway and slamming Bubba in the side. It wasn't enough force to knock him over—he was too strong for that—but it did push him off course, allowing me the precious necessary seconds to get back on my feet. Once I did, I was overwhelmed with equal parts gratitude and distress.

Lillian was backing slowly away from Bubba, never taking her eyes off the mighty steed as he gathered his bearings for another charge. “Sorry, boss, I got tired of waiting in the car.”

“I'm not usually one for insubordination, but I suppose I'll have to look past it this time.” While I'd have far rather recounted this tale to Lillian, which would have allowed me to glaze over the more dangerous parts and omit certain details entirely, her intervention had kept me from being trampled on the floor. Out of the two options, perhaps having to put a little more effort into my lies wasn't such a bad result.

“What's the plan? One of us distracts this thing while the other drains it dry?” Lillian asked.

“No!” I spat the word without thinking, my mind flashing back to that night with Colin. Lillian wasn't the type to hesitate, and if I didn't stop her right away, then Bubba might be in danger. “This is a client; he's just had a bad reaction to a potion. Right now, the alchemist is fetching an antidote, so all we need to do is keep him distracted until she arrives.”

It didn't take any manner of expert to see the doubt and, worse, curiosity in Lillian's eyes. She voiced none of it, though, merely nodding her head stiffly and replying, “You're the boss.”

After that, there was little time for talk, as Bubba tore after us once again. It was still hellish to try and dodge his assaults, but having Lillian in the room helped a great deal. We spread out instinctively, and even in the limited confines of the lab, he could only go after one of us at a time. That allowed the other to regroup and prepare for when his attention invariably waned—sometimes helped along by yelling when one of us was getting backed into a corner. Together, we managed to keep him smashing about without being trampled until the wooden door opened a small sliver and Amy's voice slunk out from behind it.

“How are we looking?”

“We're going to have to write off everything in here as collateral damage

from a testing procedure, but otherwise, not bad,” I replied. “My new employee stepped in to lend a hand, making the task far more manageable.” While it sounded like (and technically was) praise, my real goal was to make sure Amy knew that we weren’t alone before she let anything too important slip. Granted, there was little chance of that with Bubba as a far more eminent threat; however, I’d found it never hurt to be overly cautious. Especially not with my group of friends.

“Well, I brought the calm-down juice. Loaded it up and got it ready for injection, too.”

“Do I want to know why you have that sort of equipment on hand?” I asked, keeping a careful eye on Lillian as she gracefully darted out of Bubba’s path.

“Not every parahuman has a mouth, Fred. I have to cater to all sorts of clients,” Amy replied, a bit more sharply than usual. Evidently, the experience of accidentally morphing her friend and seeing her lab torn to shambles had left her in a less-than-stellar mood, which I could scarcely fault her for.

“I didn’t consider that,” I admitted. “To the matter at hand, though . . . how do we administer the cure? Bubba doesn’t seem too keen on letting anyone get close to him at the moment. At least, not unless he’s trying to mow them down.”

“Seeing as I’m just an alchemist and you’re two strapping vampires, I’d say one of you is going to have to get the drop on him and jam it in. Catch.” With no more warning than that, Amy flung open the door and tossed a metal syringe at me. My hand moved on its own, which was a great mercy, because if I’d had time to think, I surely would have let it clatter to the ground, rather snatching the cure out of mid-air. The moment my hand closed around it, the sharp scent hit my nose and caused it to wrinkle.

Silver. Not the whole device, but at least the needle. It made sense; therians were just as weak to the stuff as vampires—well, most vampires, anyway—and without knowing how tough his skin currently was, this was the only method to ensure the syringe broke through. All the same, I tried to look ill-at-ease holding such a thing, in case Lillian had picked up on the scent, as well. Since I wasn’t technically touching it, I shouldn’t be weakened; yet, all the same, it seemed prudent to show some discomfort. The absolute last thing I needed was for her to realize I’d found a way to shake off one of our kind’s biggest vulnerabilities.

“Lillian! Can you manage to make him hold still for a second or so? *Without* hurting him.”

“Is this thing a therian?” Lillian yelled at me, bolting out of the way and whirling around so that Bubba would be charging past her into a corner.

“In normal form, yes,” I replied.

“Stopping it without hurting it is probably impossible, but I can at least



limit the damage to what their kind can heal. Will that work?" She couldn't turn toward me to ask; her eyes were unwaveringly on Bubba as he lined up his next attack. While I wasn't particularly fond of the idea, it seemed we were going to have to make the best of a bad situation. Better Bubba recover from a few bruises than any of us get serious injuries.

"Keep it as limited as you can," I instructed.

That was all the permission she needed. Bubba charged at her again, but rather than jump to the side, Lillian ran forward, meeting the challenge head on. Her posture dropped as she went into a slide, purposely putting herself down between those trampling legs. With movements so fast and precise I could barely follow them, Lillian threw a kick directly into one of Bubba's legs, just as his weight settled on top of it. I heard the snap and pop before I saw the knee bend, collapsing and bringing several hundred pounds of horse down with it.

Bubba's screech was awful, and I did my best to ignore it as I raced forward. He could heal fast—I'd seen that firsthand many a time—and if this version of my friend managed to get back on his feet, it would have a vendetta to settle. Wasting no time, I drove the syringe deep into his flank, the silver easily piercing his usually durable skin. Jamming the plunger down with my thumb, I didn't so much as wiggle the device until I was sure every drop of antidote had made it into Bubba's system.

The effects were visible almost instantly; a wave of brown washed out from the spot where I'd stuck him, overtaking the ashy black color of his altered form. As it spread, I noticed that Bubba was getting smaller, the terrifying horse turning back to my friend's true, diminutive form. His breathing was labored, however, and I could still see the broken angle of his leg even as his body morphed. Carefully, being sure not to antagonize him, I laid my hand on Bubba's neck.

"It's okay. I'm here. Amy's here, and you're going to be fine." The sound of plodding footsteps on shattered debris drew my attention, and I saw Amy walking over.

"Sorry about that, Bubba. Next time, I promise to filter out the aggressive tendencies inherent in their magic."

"How about we just not have a next time?" I proposed.

"Fred, do you know where the world would be if people gave up every time they had one little failure?" Amy countered.

"I'm okay with a lack of progress if the failures involve my friends being in danger." I could feel Bubba's racing pulse through his neck, but thankfully, it was beginning to calm down as his returned to his usual pony form.

"He would have been fine, eventually," Amy said. "It was a test potion, so none of the ingredients could have lasted longer than a day. I just didn't want him to get himself into trouble before it wore off."

“Excuse me . . . are you Amy Wells? Student to Gideon, King of the West?” Lillian had circled around behind us, and was standing by Amy with her hands clasped together in what was either real or very well-done mock excitement.

“‘Student’ might be a bit of a strong term. He just showed me a few things, mostly so I could make better products for him,” Amy replied. After a second, her brow furrowed. “Wait, how do you know about that?”

“Oh, the House of Turva makes a point of researching everyone of significant status and power when we move to a new area, and as an associate of the King of the West, you, of course, caught their attention.” I didn’t know much about vampire culture, but this seemed like the sort of thing someone should probably be embarrassed to admit, and yet, it didn’t leave even so much as a dent in Lillian’s excitement. “I have to say, it’s a real honor to meet you. People talk about how powerful your potions are for states around.”

They did? I knew Amy was talented—the mere fact that Gideon was a client spoke to that fact—but I had never realized she was quite that well-regarded. It didn’t seem to shock Amy much, though, as she shrugged off the praise in her usual blasé manner.

“Thanks, I guess. Sorry our friend almost smashed you.”

“It was well worth it to meet such an icon,” Lillian replied. If she took note of the fact that Amy referred to us all as friends, rather than business acquaintances, she didn’t show it. Maybe I’d get lucky and she’d simply chalk it up to Amy being lazy with titles, or overly friendly.

Bubba, in the meantime, had fully transformed back to his usual weresteed shape and size, not so much as a speck of black or fire left on him. The glassy black eyes stared up at us, saying the apology that his mouth wasn’t currently able to convey. For a moment, he began to warp, heading back to his human form, but before he could do more than start the shift, Amy whacked him hard on the nose.

“None of that, now. You know you heal faster when transformed, and that leg needs to patch itself up,” Amy chided. She took a good look at the wound, which was already better than it had been moments prior. “Damn, your new assistant really got a piece of him.”

“I’m actually a trainee, not an assistant,” Lillian corrected. “But I do believe in fulfilling orders to the best of my ability.”

Before I could tell her that some orders could be handled a little more gently, the sound of Albert’s ringtone began blaring from my phone. Slipping the sleek device out of my pocket, I accepted the call and pulled the phone to my ear.

“What’s going on, Albert?”

“Um . . . hey, Fred. I know this—” Albert was cut off by the sound of screaming in the background, at least one of the voices belonging to Neil.

“Sorry, I know this isn’t the best night for it, but I think I need your help on something. I was dropping off the packets, just like you ordered; only, when I got to the fifth one, instead of signing the receipt, the couple just started yelling at each other. Things . . . sort of got worse from there.” Another bout of screaming, followed by what sounded like the thud of something dense hitting a wall.

“Neil and I are kind of stuck here,” Albert continued. “And I could call the authorities, but I thought, since the papers got them fighting, maybe there was a non-agent way to fix this. ‘Cause . . . well . . . you know.”

I did know, all too well. He was smart enough not to say Krystal’s name, but she was the authority he would turn to. And if Albert called in an agent, the situation was getting resolved. It just might not be in the most peaceful of methods. Aside from concern for my clients, I also had to worry about the reputation of my company. Being too closely linked with agents could be bad for business—a lot of parahumans tried to keep themselves as far away from the treaty-enforcers as possible.

Of course, even on the best of nights, I’d be hesitant to head into such a situation. With Lillian in tow, it was all the more problematic. Still, Albert was right. If I could figure out what in the documents had caused the issue and find a resolution, then it would be the best ending for everyone involved.

Except, possibly, me.

“Give me the address, Albert,” I said, noting the interest in Lillian’s expression. “We’ll head there right away.”

## 7.

It took us nearly twenty minutes to arrive at the destination, even with me breaking my usual fastidious adherence to the speed limits (I went up to ten miles over in some spots). I'd recognized the address as soon as Albert gave it to me; even in my line of work, the number of ranches I called on was minimal. The Capra Ranch was to the north of Winslow, in one of the most rustic sections. Unlike where Charlotte Manor had been located, this piece of land was never attempted to be industrialized, and in fact hosted a lovely farmer's market on weekends that I would have happily attended, if it weren't held during the day.

Gerda and Oskar were the kindly couple who ran and owned the Capra Ranch—a satyress and satyr, respectively. I remembered driving out to meet them a few months back, their goat legs carefully hidden under thick overalls and custom boots. They had served me delicious cheese and asked me to carefully go through their costs and incomes to see why business was up, but profits were down. It had been a relatively simple job. All I had uncovered was that they were overpaying a few suppliers, hardly the sort of thing I expected to cause a ruckus. Yet, as I pulled my car around to the rear, I could clearly hear heated voices yelling at each other from inside the farmhouse.

"Please don't tell me to stay put again." Lillian's request came before I'd even gotten my seat belt off. It was prescient as well, because the next words out of my mouth were indeed going to be orders to sit tight while I handled this. "I'm here to learn about customer service, remember?"

"What's happening in there is hardly a standard part of the job," I told her.

"You do remember that we just came from subduing a rampaging therian, right? Seems to me it comes up often enough to be worth learning." Lillian took off her own seat belt and slung her bag over her arm. "Besides, you might need backup. Once satyrs get going on a tear, it's hard to calm them down."

"Lillian, I know the last stop set something of a bad precedent, but at Fletcher Accounting Services, we do *not* go into meetings planning on physically engaging our clients."

"No, but there's something to be said for self-defense," Lillian replied. "I promise not to lay a hand on anyone unless you tell me to, though. And don't act like you don't need the help. I know your assistant is stuck in there."

This, at least, didn't come as a surprise. I knew my own hearing well enough to expect that she'd been able to hear Albert's side of the call. I still scowled at her nonetheless. "Privacy and confidentiality are important aspects

of the work I do. From now on, I expect you to tune out my business calls.”

“Will do.” Lillian looked as if she meant to say more, but a loud thud from inside the farmhouse made us both jump. “Sounds like we should really get in there.”

Much as I tried to think of one, I didn’t have a good reason to offer up for why she should stay in the car. I could hardly pretend to be worried for her safety—the way she’d brought down an augmented Bubba made it clear that, of the two of us, she would be more capable in dangerous situations. Not to mention the fact that, with no idea what I was walking into, having the help might actually make a difference again. Most compelling of all, though, was the fact that Albert and Neil were stuck in the middle of whatever was happening, and that meant getting them extricated came before anything else.

With a begrudging sigh, I nodded, and the two of us stepped out of my eco-consciously sized car. Moving quickly, I knocked once on the front door, which caused it to drift open, as it had evidently not been closed in the first place. This gave us an excellent view into the living room, and a sight so strange we were both struck by a momentary pause.

Gerda and Oskar, the two lovely people I remembered from our original meeting, were literally locking horns (which I was certain they didn’t have when last I saw them) in the middle of the room. The furniture had been thrown about, and the dents on the wooden walls answered the question of what had been making the loud thuds. Backed in a corner, tucked behind what looked like the remains of a coffee table, were Albert and Neil. Albert had planted his sword, still sheathed, between the battling couple and them, while Neil was scratching some sort of rune into the coffee table and muttering under his breath. All of this came with the soundtrack of Gerda and Oskar both trying to yell over the other, so deep in anger and insults that I could barely piece together more than a few words of their dialogue, none of which I’d feel comfortable repeating in my retelling of the incident. I mean, there’s swearing, and then there’s two satyrs cursing at one another.

“Fred!” Albert popped his head up as he caught sight of me and Lillian in the doorway. Somehow, his one innocent exclamation got the attention of the battling couple, who yanked their horns apart and turned to face me.

“There he is!” Gerda yelled, voice nothing like the one she’d had when offering me glass after glass of sweet tea. “Tell this lying old bastard that the jig is up!”

“Fred, it’s about damn time,” Oskar hollered. “I’ve been trying to make your assistant explain to her that the truth is right there on the page.”

“They’ve been screaming a lot, don’t want us to leave, and I can’t figure out what any of it is about!” Albert yelled.

“This accounting stuff is a lot more interesting than I was expecting,” Lillian muttered, which was the exact opposite of what I wanted to hear from

her.

All the voices were swirling around, trying to top the others and clamoring for attention. Rather than try and engage with any of them, I stormed into the room, grabbed the tattered (but not torn) packet I'd given Albert for delivery, and slapped it crisply against my hand.

"Gerda. Oskar. I want to help you, I do—"

My words were drowned out under a fresh tidal wave of yelling from each half of the couple, both trying to make their points so enthusiastically that they weren't even bothering with an explanation. In spite of their aggression, I remained calm, waiting until there was a lull and trying again.

"I can't offer any perspective on this unless—"

Another fresh wave of screaming. I continued to be patient, ready to wait for as long as it took to get them calmed down enough to explain the situation.

This time, however, they were the ones cut off. Not by words, but by the sudden audible crack of wood being fiercely splintered. We all turned to find that Lillian, still dutifully standing by the entrance, had driven her fist completely through the door with a single punch, and was now carefully brushing the splinters away from her unmarked hand.

"I believe Fred was trying to say something, before you interrupted him." There was no threat in her words, yet the hole in the door spoke volumes. Gerda and Oskar both seemed to shrink back, looking at her, and me, with an expression I'd encountered more than once since my transformation, and loathed more with every occurrence.

Fear. She'd reminded them that we were stronger, and now they were scared of her. Of us.

"Lillian, go wait in the car."

"But—"

"You are *done* here. Unless you want to be fired outright, go wait in the car. Now." It wasn't often that I found the nerve to be so forceful, but this was something I absolutely couldn't tolerate. My business, my very life, was built upon other parahumans looking past the reputation that other vampires had cultivated. I couldn't allow anyone to associate Fletcher Accounting Services with that kind of aggression, not unless it was a matter of life and death. Yelling didn't qualify. Sooner or later, voices got tired.

Lillian stared at me for several seconds, then spun around and left, presumably heading back toward the car. I looked at Gerda and Oskar, suitably cowed for the moment, and decided to capitalize on their silence.

"I am very, deeply sorry for that. Lillian is a new employee; though, one more stunt like that, and that won't be the case any longer. Fletcher Accounting Services is going to replace your door, and I'll be doing the next six months of budgetary maintenance for free as an apology. If you no longer

wish to do business with us, I understand, and will happily get whatever new accountant you choose up to speed on your situation.”

Some of the color that had drained from each of their cheeks began to return, and Oskar even took a step toward me. “Nah, Fred, you can’t control what someone else does. We accept the apology.”

“Thank you, very much,” I replied. “Now, can we please, in calm and rational voices, discuss what in my findings led you to suddenly begin fighting with one another?”

“A fight? This ain’t much of a fight. Barely even an argument,” Gerda informed me. “Guess it might seem that way from the outside, though. We satyrs and satyresses are just passionate. And a bit stubborn.”

“What caused the ‘discussion’ was that I looked through your pages and found out she’s been double paying for the cow’s feed,” Oskar told me, his tone beginning to heat up a bit more. “Now, I know that’s her cousin’s company, so she’s probably been paying twice just to squirrel a little money away from me. And the only reason she’d do that is if she was gambling again.”

“Like hell that’s what started it,” Gerda shot back. “We started a row because *you’re* paying three times what the fencing costs to your old drinking buddy who runs the company. And so help me god, Oskar, if you’re back on the bottle, I’ll break it over your thick skull. Again.” From the way she was flexing her hands, something told me she didn’t mean it as a figure of speech.

They were beginning to fume again, which was actually a relief, since it meant they weren’t afraid I’d forcefully shut them down. Plus, now that I knew what the actual issues were, it allowed me to dig through the report and see how much truth there was to the claims. As the satyr couple started squabbling once again, I sat down in the sole remaining chair to dig through my compiled report.

Even as I worked, though, my mind was out in the car with Lillian. I didn’t regret the choice I’d made in sending her away, but that didn’t mean there wouldn’t be consequences to it.

My night might very well end with a fight that would put the owners of the Capra Ranch to shame.

## 8.

It took a while, but I was eventually able to piece together what had caused the errors. Double paying for feed was an innocent mistake—both Gerda and Oskar had thought they were supposed to set up the automatic withdrawals from their bank account and neither had checked with the other, causing the same amount to go out twice per month. As for the fencing, while the cost was exorbitant, it also matched the receipts provided by the company. I recommended that they find a new vendor, as this one was clearly gouging them. It was technically possible that Oskar was funneling cash through a friend to feed a secret drinking habit, but judging from the anger at hearing his friend was ripping them off, it seemed unlikely. That, or Oskar was a far better actor than I could have imagined. Either way, my work was done, and I liberated Neil and Albert, who were both handed cartons of baked goods from Gerda as apology for what she called “the slight inconvenience.”

I saw both of them back to Neil’s car—an old sedan most likely inherited from a family member who’d purchased cars back when they were made of thick metal frames and came with ashtrays in the armrests. It occurred to me as I watched their taillights fade down the road that I’d never actually met any of Neil’s family. Albert’s either, but that was understandable, as they all believed him to be dead. I knew I was stalling, avoiding heading back to my own car and facing the fuming vampire waiting inside. There was no getting around it, though. Not unless I was willing to abandon my car and run back to town—which was tempting, I will admit, but would leave Lillian for Oskar and Gerda to deal with. And that seemed like bad customer service no matter how I sliced it.

I rounded the farm house to see my hybrid still in one piece, which I hoped was a good sign. Lillian was sitting inside, staring out her window and away from my approaching form. She was still aware of me, her senses were too good for her not to be, but she was pretending not to notice. That was fine by me, as I would take frustrated silence over fury any day of the week. Popping open the door, I slid into my seat and started the car’s engine. I said nothing as I put on my seat belt, giving Lillian ample time to open the conversation with an explanation or an apology if she so desired. When my silence was echoed, it became obvious that I was going to have to start things off.

“I’m sorry if my tone was too harsh in there. The situation was chaotic, and I had to try and salvage things as quickly as possible, which meant you had to leave. Still, I do wish I’d found a gentler way to voice that.”



“Salvage things?” Lillian turned from the window, surprise overtaking the pinched annoyance she’d been wearing seconds before. “Fredrick, I had the situation perfectly in hand. They were silent, willing to listen, and ready to sign whatever you put in front of them. I fixed everything, and you cast me out for it.”

“You didn’t ‘fix’ anything,” I told her. “You just made my clients afraid.”

“They *should* be afraid.” Her surprise was morphing to puzzlement before my eyes. “You are a vampire, one of the most feared and powerful types of parahumans out there. The very fact that they continued speaking when you entered the room was a slap in the face. All I did was restore the natural order. And without touching a single person, I might add.”

I think I would have preferred it if Lillian had been at least a little miffed as she spoke. If she were angry, then I could have pretended the words came without thought and forgiven them as such. But Lillian wasn’t mad. She didn’t even seem overly prideful as she spoke of the natural order. The only emotion that came across was confusion, like I was the weird one. Which, when viewed objectively, I suppose I was.

“Is that what it’s like inside your clan?” I asked. “Vampires are seen as the best, and the other parahumans are lesser?”

“Not the best, just among the top. We’re aware of our abilities, and our limitations,” Lillian countered. “As for the others, the satyrs and mages and therians, they are our food, Fredrick, just like the humans. A bit more difficult to hunt, but the nutrition is far superior. Or are you honestly saying that you don’t use this job as a way to get in close to other parahumans so you can feed on them?”

Slowly, I lowered my head until the rims of my glasses were pressed against the steering wheel’s leather. *That* was what she, what her clan, thought I was doing? Running an elaborate ruse to take blood from unsuspecting parahumans? Everything came into sharper focus now. Lillian wasn’t here to learn about me, she was here to learn about my business. How it worked, and likely how it could be replicated. A blood-stealing venture that flew under the nose of a man like Richard was the sort of thing any worthwhile clan would be interested in.

“Lillian, I am going to say this once, and only once, so please listen carefully. I do *not* feed on other parahumans. Or regular humans, for that matter. I buy my blood through the Agency’s supply system. My accounting business is not a way for me to drink from anyone. It’s just an accounting business. Parahumans run businesses, and they sometimes need as much help as anyone else.”

“I’m sure they do, but if you’re not drinking from them, then why would you actually do this job?” Lillian asked.

“Because I like it. Because I’m good at it. Because it fills a very needed

role in the parahuman community. Why do you think I was looking for new employees in the first place? There are so many of our kind out there who need the help I offer that there's more business than I can handle," I told her.

"Really? I mean . . . we just assumed you were either going to feed on the new employee or you wanted an accomplice to help make disposal easier," Lillian said.

"I assure you, that is not the case. What I need is another accountant, someone who can help with the workload." I raised my head from the steering wheel and looked at Lillian, who seemed oddly at peace with discovering she'd been lent to a real accountant rather than an ingenious blood thief. "There's nothing hidden about me or my business. What you see is what you get."

"That a fact?" Lillian leaned back, taking in my full profile. "While I'll admit it doesn't seem like you're eating people, you can't tell me there isn't something going on here. You happen to know one of the preeminent mages in the state, are good enough friends with a therian to care about his health even as he's attacking, and have what I'm pretty sure was a zombie on the payroll as your assistant. That's not normal for a vampire, accountant or not."

"What can I say? I was left without a clan." Putting the car into drive, I swung us around, heading away from Gerda and Oskar's ranch. "I didn't get a ready-made family, or a template for who I was supposed to hate, so I ended up making friends with anyone I got along with, regardless of their parahuman traits."

"So it seems. I am curious, though, since you've worked for Richard Alderson, have you ever had occasion to meet the King of the West?" She wasn't even trying to hide how closely she was watching my face for a lie. The other things were small coincidences, nothing that linked me to the vampire of rumor. If I had a good relationship with a dragon, though . . . well, very few vampires could honestly claim such a thing.

"I met him on the first night I met Richard, actually," I told her. "It was one of the absolute scariest experiences of my life, before and after undeath."

"He wasn't nice?" Lillian asked.

"He was *Gideon*." I shuddered involuntarily at just the memory of that night. "Have you ever been near a dragon? Had their attention focused fully on you? That aura of theirs is like nothing else. Your body begins to spasm as your brain loses all cohesive thought, filling only with animalistic screams of panic and terror. It left me so catatonic that I had to be carried from the building. When I went back to work on Richard's taxes, it was only something I could manage because Gideon wasn't there."

My words, carefully chosen, were all completely true. I just left out the part where Gideon came back to rescue Sally, giving me a drop of his blood so I could bring her home, and eventually filling me with more of it to later

break him out of a magical cage. Disclosing all of that would pretty much mean the jig was up.

"I've met lesser dragons," Lillian said, after soaking in my story. "And even they were impossible to function around. I can't even imagine what the King of the West's aura would be like." She paused, watching the street signs go by as we drove back into a more developed neighborhood. "Do you really think there's a vampire out there who was able to withstand it? The rumors people have been passing along, about a vampire who won the dragon's respect . . . they must have a will of absolute iron, if they exist."

"I can't say I've ever met a vampire I thought was strong-willed enough to pull such a thing off." A bit self-deprecating, if honest assessment of my own abilities, but still not a lie. "All I have learned since I became undead is that this is a much bigger, stranger world than I ever realized when I was alive. Maybe there is a vampire out there who can stand up to a dragon's aura. If one of us can be happy as an accountant, that doesn't seem any less unreasonable."

"Still wrapping my head around that one," Lillian said. "This is really it? You just . . . do people's budgets and taxes and stuff? No intimidation, or forced feedings, or any of it?"

"I'm not sure how you think a business works, but I rely heavily on word of mouth for my clients. If I tried scaring them into doing what I wanted, or, heaven forbid, assaulted them, my reputation would fall apart within the span of a week. Which is why I had to come down so hard on you with Gerda and Oskar." I pulled onto the small loop that circled Winslow, heading back to Charlotte Manor. After that last stop, it seemed prudent to call it an early night before more could go wrong.

"No, I get it now. I'm sorry. What I did was out of line. It's just . . ." She tilted her head back, her dark hair bunching up on the headrest. "I've been with the Turva clan for so long. More years by far than I was alive for. They're all about intimidation and power plays, the dominance of the vampire species. You live with that, surrounded by it all the time, and it's easy to forget that there are other ways to get by."

"Maybe it's a good thing that I won't be much help to them," I said.

"Yeah." A shadow that had nothing to do with the passing street lamps fell over Lillian's face. "Someone who could get them parahuman blood under the table would have been a lot more useful than just an accountant."

"Do I . . . should I be worried about not being useful?" My words hung in the air between us, the unspoken topic that had been present all night finally beginning to tear its way into reality. Lillian's gaze wandered out the window again, watching the few other cars out so late zip by as we puttered along at the speed limit.

"Probably," she said at last. "The House of Turva is moving into Winslow

full force. They'll play nice with the therians and stick to the treaties, since the King of the West is here, but they've never been much for competition. If you had the backing of a clan, that would be one thing; there's a lot of politics involved when dealing with fellow clans. As an abandoned vampire, though . . .” Lillian let her voice trail off. There wasn't anything more that needed to be said. I wasn't one of them, and without a clan to protect me, I had limited options. Be absorbed or be destroyed; those were my most likely scenarios. Absorption might not even be on the table.

We rode in silence the rest of the way back to Charlotte Manor. I wanted to press her for more, to ask about exactly what they might do. Part of me even wanted to ask her to lie, but that piece of me was foolish. Sooner or later, they'd realize the truth. Unless I actually started assaulting clients, it was an impossible façade to keep up. There was no sense in dragging Lillian down with me. She, at least, had given me a bit of warning.

Thanks to Lillian, if I wanted to, there was still time to book a ticket to Boarback.

That thought was heavy on my mind as I pulled into Charlotte Manor's parking lot. I was so lost in my musings that I almost didn't notice the unfamiliar gray minivan parked a few spaces up. It had government plates, and no windows aside from those in the front. Part of me wondered if the Turva clan was moving already, somehow getting the word that I was useless to them. Then, before my eyes, the back of the van was ripped off from the inside, revealing three white creatures with snapping jaws. If I lived a thousand years, I would never forget that sound. It haunted my nightmares, was tied to one of my worst memories. Dozens of those things had surrounded us the night Quinn kidnapped Krystal, the night he almost killed me.

The night I saw him tear out her throat, before I knew such wounds only made her stronger. Ghouls, that's what was leaping out of the van. Mindless appetites given physical form, they knew only hunger. And, before I could so much as yell, they were racing right toward my car.

## 9.

A whole lot happened in a very short span of time. I screamed at the ghouls' approach, while Lillian's hand dipped into her pantsuit and came out with a knife that looked like it was built to carve bone. The ghouls raced toward my car, their jaws clacking and eyes empty as they endeavored to lock those crooked teeth around our flesh. Gunshots rang through the night, turning two of the ghouls' skulls to mist and shattering my windshield. Because of the cracks, I could only barely see someone bolt around from the other side of the van, tackling the third ghoul and pressing a weapon to its temple. Another shot, and the monster went limp.

Lillian was out the door before I could say a word, so I forced my hands to grab the handle and yank it open, determined not to let her face whatever lurked out there alone. As it turned out, the well-meaning gesture was wasted. Not a single ghoul was left moving, or even with their skulls intact. What did greet us, however, was Krystal sitting atop the third ghoul's back, blood all over her sweatshirt as she removed her gun from the chunky mess that used to be its head. She glanced up, noticing Lillian and me for the first time.

"You're . . . uh . . . you're home early, Freddy. Kind of thought we had another hour or so before you showed up."

"We?" I'd barely gotten the question out when it was answered; Arch came walking around from the other side of the van, his own gun still out and ready to fire. I had a pretty good idea who'd taken out the first two ghouls with those perfect headshots; Krystal was good, but not flawless.

"You just smoked those things." Lillian was gazing at Krystal and Arch with a new expression, one I'd yet to see on her serene, always-certain face. Fear. Even if it hadn't been said out loud, she knew what she was looking at. The pieces were falling into place in her subconscious, and her sense of vampire superiority was crumbling quickly. "I thought you did software design."

"Would you believe I also play a lot of first-person shooters?" Krystal asked. Her glasses were gone, left off since she hadn't been planning on playing her part so soon, and the deferential attitude was just as absent. She was on the clock, which meant the real Krystal had resurfaced, and there didn't seem to be much purpose in pretending otherwise.

"Fredrick, your girlfriend is an agent!" For a moment, I thought it was an accusation, which I was more than braced for. Then I caught sight of the panic in her eyes and the frantic gestures she was making. Lillian was trying to warn me, to give me a chance to escape. Even if I'd wanted to move, though,

I couldn't. The sudden crushing boulder of guilt over deceiving her was weighing me down far too much to manage even a shuffle.

"Lillian . . . I know." Had I shot her, I don't think she could have looked more surprised. It seemed like we might get to find out, though, as Arch turned his weapon toward Lillian.

"It seems like this is the sort of conversation best had inside, wouldn't we all agree?" Arch's tone wasn't exactly what I would call cordial—he was still Arch, after all—but it was calm, which meant a lot since there were three ghoulish corpses bleeding on the ground and he was holding a gun on one of us.

"Is that a threat, or a request?" Lillian spat, eyes never wavering from his weapon.

"Mandatory debriefing. You just witnessed three captured parahumans try to escape custody. We need get your account of how it went down for the record, and to make sure it doesn't happen again." Arch kept his weapon aimed, but nodded his head toward Charlotte Manor. "I can cite the treaty precedent, if you need it."

"How about everybody chills the fuck out for a second," Krystal suggested. "Lil, I know there's some explaining to do, so why don't you come inside and ask us whatever questions you've got. I'll get the manor staff to whip up some grub. Arch, put the damn gun down; she's not going to bolt into the night."

"What makes you so sure?" Arch asked.

"Because she's the one who really wants an explanation, which I'm offering to give her," Krystal said. "Plus, she knows we've got her name and clan, so running wouldn't do much good. If we told them we wanted to question her about something, the Turvas would likely hand over her head and say she broke an internal law. They're not big on their people talking to agents."

If any part of me had wondered about the idea of being pulled into the Turva clan, that perhaps it wouldn't be so bad, the fact that Lillian didn't dispute Krystal's theory quickly put those notions to bed. Instead of arguing, my fellow vampire simply turned and walked into Charlotte Manor wordlessly, leaving the three of us behind.

"Why in the hell didn't you give me a heads up you were coming home early?" Krystal asked.

"I didn't think about it," I said. "Tonight has been kind of . . . hectic."

With that, I launched into the story of what we'd dealt with so far: Bubba's transformation, the satyr couple's fight, Lillian's revelation of what the Turvas thought of my business. By the time I was done, Krystal and Arch had thrown the three ghoulish corpses into the back of the van and jerry-rigged the door to stay shut.

"Guess the jig is officially up. No need to stay uncomfortable." Krystal

yanked the blood-ruined sweatshirt off to reveal a black tank-top underneath. She popped open the barely working rear door and hurled the soaked garment into the back with the corpses. "What's the play now, Freddy?"

"I honestly don't know." The night had started with a plan. Maybe not a great one, but it had been there, an idea of how to handle things that might get me out unscathed. Now, though, all of it was in shambles. Lillian knew everything and would report it back to the Turva clan. There was always the chance that me dating an agent could buy some protection, but Krystal herself had said she was limited by the law. If they found a way to come after me without breaking the treaties that bound them, she'd either have to stand by or violate the law herself. Running seemed more and more like the only real option we had. And yet, part of me was still resisting. I didn't want to leave Winslow, even if every rational part of me screamed that it was the smart thing to do. If there was even a chance of staying, I wanted to try and uncover it.

"Let's just talk to her," I said at last. "Maybe we can find common ground, or reach an understanding, or something."

"Even if you can, she doesn't speak for the clan as a whole." Arch obviously noticed the surprised look on my face, since he continued with an explanation. "Krystal brought me up to speed on your situation."

"Arch, do I even want to know why you have a van full of ghouls parked outside Charlotte Manor?" I asked, realizing for the first time just how insane that really was.

"You might want to, but you aren't going to find out. It's confidential," he told me.

"In the future, if you could avoid bringing dangerous creatures to suburban areas, I'd really appreciate it." I didn't even try to temper the sarcasm in my voice; my patience for the day had worn almost completely through.

"Can't make that promise," Arch replied, unbothered by my tone. That was about par for the course with him, though; I'd been the silly one for expecting to make a dent in his stoic countenance.

"Let's just go get this done." I walked up the drive to the manor, Krystal arriving at my side seconds later. She said nothing, just took my hand and squeezed it tight, reminding me once again that she was there. If I hadn't already told her that I loved her, it would have burst from my lips in that moment. Curiously, having said those words to one another already, there wasn't any need to speak them as we made our way into the house. We both knew, just as we knew that however this all went down, we would face it together. Rain or shine, we were in it, side by side.

Lillian was waiting for us in the dining room, a slice of apple pie sitting untouched in front of her. One of the waiter versions of Charlotte stood

quietly nearby, awaiting any order or request that Lillian might make. We took our seats, and seconds later another waiter arrived, setting pie down in front of both Krystal and me.

“Coffee, too, if you don’t mind,” Krystal requested. Our waiter nodded and headed into the kitchen, where he would wait as long as coffee normally took to brew before returning with the magically conjured cup. We didn’t really need to pretend at this point, but I held my tongue. Charlotte’s secret had no relation to mine, and it wasn’t my place to give hers away without cause.

“You’re him.” Lillian’s arms were crossed, and the stare in her eyes could have shamed a sociopath as she glared at me from across the table. “I can’t believe I didn’t see it earlier. That zombie had a freaking *sword* in his hands, but I thought he’d just picked it up from the junk tossed about. Friends with mages, therians, and dating an agent, plus your assistant had a weapon of destiny in his possession. You’re the vampire everyone is talking about.”

“I am.” It felt oddly good to admit that. Even with things crumbling around me, stepping out of the shadow of deceit was freeing. “And I’m not. The things you’ve heard about me, some of them are true, but only in the most technical sense of the term. I didn’t pretend to be someone I’m not, or lie about what I do for a living. I really am just a Certified Public Parahuman Accountant. Nothing more.”

“Except that you’ve consorted with dragons, and brokered a peace with the leader of the therians,” Lillian snapped.

“Like I said, technically true, but there were extenuating circumstances.”

“Well, I’m listening,” Lillian told us. “Explain the circumstances to me. Let’s hear the truth behind the rumors.”

My eyes darted to Krystal, who met them with a slight shrug. This was my choice to make, and while I knew she would back me in whatever I decided, she couldn’t make the call for me. Giving Lillian information was dangerous. Everything I said, every weakness I revealed, all of it could be used against me. If that happened, though, was I really any worse off? Right now, fleeing was far and away the best option before me. Talking to Lillian wouldn’t take that off the table, not with Arch and Krystal on my side. But it might open up a new path, one I couldn’t see on my own. I was already on the brink of losing everything, why not roll the dice one more time?

“I’d say it all really started when I decided to go to my high school reunion . . . .”



## 10.

By the time I was done, the pie, along with a few cups of coffee and glasses of wine, had all long been put away. I didn't tell Lillian everything, the personal information and secrets of others never touched my tongue, but I did give her a good overview of what the last few years had been like. She was skeptical at first; however, after one story led to the next, she slowly began to come around and see how it was possible for me to have technically pulled off so many seemingly impressive achievements without actually being the vampire rumors made me out to be.

The one secret of my own that I skipped over was my immunity to silver. Showing her some trust, seeing if she might be willing to help me find a path to peaceful coexistence with her people, that was all well and good, but it wouldn't hurt to have a secret ace in the hole. The House of Turva not knowing silver didn't affect me could easily be the difference between escape and capture in a dire situation. I skimmed past it, wrapping up my tale with the events of the night Colin the vampire hunter had appeared.

"This was really not what I expected when Petre put me on the assignment." Lillian took a long sip from her glass of wine—a chardonnay that, while certainly of high quality, was far too sweet for my liking. "I figured a week or so to learn your operation, plus a few days for the seduction —"

"Pardon me?" Krystal didn't reach for her gun, but she did grip her coffee mug a bit tighter.

"I didn't know he had a girlfriend when they told me to come work for him," Lillian explained. "And do you think I really wanted to do that in the first place? No offense, Fredrick. You're a nice enough guy, but it's not like I'm keen on being ordered to seduce people I'm not even into."

"Then why do it?" I asked. My familiarity with the treaties and laws of parahuman kind was lacking in anything aside from the fiscal department, yet I couldn't imagine being part of a clan meant completely surrendering one's freedom.

"It's just the way things are done." Another sip, this time enough to nearly drain the glass. Seconds later, the kitchen door opened and one of Charlotte's many waiter forms appeared with a fresh chardonnay in hand. She might not have name-brand, but there was never a need to go thirsty while staying at Charlotte Manor.

"Do you know why I got turned in the first place?" Lillian continued. "It's because they were trying to get at a local politician of the time, collecting dirt

to use so they could leverage control over him. And he supposedly had a thing for dark-haired women. That's it. I was given eternal life just so they could try and tempt some mayor into cheating on his wife."

"That is . . . really shitty," I said.

"Funniest part: it didn't even work. Turns out, he was gay. But of course, in those days, no one could actually admit to such a thing, especially not while in public office. The whole 'dark hair' thing was just a rumor; as far as I know, he never touched a woman, which suited his wife fine. They were what we used to call a 'good fit,' for the times."

"Speculation?" Arch asked.

"Very much confirmed." A bit of a smile appeared on Lillian's face—the first time since we'd been attacked by ghouls.

"Wait . . . ." Understanding set in at the sight of her grin, followed immediately by a fresh bout of confusion. "Then, why would they ask you to try and seduce me? I'll admit I'm not the most impressive of them, but I am still male."

"There's a lot of room between zero and six, Fredrick." Lillian chuckled to herself, polishing off the last of her glass and pulling over the new one the waiter had dropped off. "That Kinsey fellow had more sense than most of the others from his time."

"Steering the conversation away from how you were supposed to fuck my boyfriend, what, exactly, did your clan expect to come out of this?" Krystal asked.

Lillian paused, seemingly considering her options. "I suppose, since it's all a bust, there's no harm in telling you. We figured that you were probably running a successful blood-harvesting business, so the goal was to learn how that worked. On the off chance that you were on the up-and-up, though, I was supposed to charm my way into your client files to get account information for all the wealthy parahumans you'd worked with. Ideally, that would have been enough to scam or outright steal from them. Funding an entire clan's relocation isn't cheap."

"Don't suppose you'd be willing to say that to a judge in the Agency." From the grim frown on Arch's face, he already knew it was going to be a no, and was asking purely out of formality.

"Even if I did, I'm just a grunt on the ladder," Lillian said. "Everyone worth holding accountable would say they had no idea I was warping a gesture of friendship with such awful intentions. The most I could accomplish would be to incriminate myself."

"Which, seeing as you just confessed in front of a pair of agents, you technically already did," Krystal pointed out.

The table fell silent as we all nursed our respective drinks and tried to figure out where to go from here with the conversation. Arch and Krystal

could haul Lillian in, but I couldn't see a way that would benefit any of us, especially Lillian. She was offering us information; repaying her with incarceration seemed like a poor trade. Finally, I spoke, determined to try and make some headway with the opportunity we'd been presented.

"Is there any chance of peace between me and the House of Turva?" I asked. "Knowing that I'm just some schmuck, with no blood business or real resources to offer, would they be willing to leave me alone?"

"No resources?" Lillian looked at me with incredulity, and Krystal's own gaze wasn't far behind. "Fredrick, you are quite possibly the most connected parahuman in the state, to say nothing of Winslow. Your lover is an agent, the powerful leader of the local therians calls you friend, you clearly have close ties to a renowned mage and the wielder of a weapon of destiny—who, apparently, is also best buds with a necromancer, of all things—and as the cherry on the sundae, you've earned the respect of an ancient dragon. If you called in enough favors, you could wipe out our entire clan."

"But I don't have those favors to call in," I protested. "And even if I did, I would never use my friends like that. They aren't assets to be tapped when I need something handled; they're people I care about."

"Oddly enough, I actually believe you," Lillian said. "Maybe it's because I've always been a bit of a softy compared to the others, or maybe you're just easy to read. Whatever it is, I honestly believe that you wouldn't try to use your friends, especially not to attack people. The problem is that almost no one else in my clan will buy that, and even if they did, they would still want to wipe you out before a century passed and you changed your mind. Time does funny things to us all, eventually."

"If I'm so connected and scary, wouldn't it make more sense to not attack me?" I was, admittedly, grasping at straws here, but with every word she said, Lillian seemed to seal my fate tighter. I was groping for anything that potentially offered hope.

"You're an abandoned vampire, Fredrick. There are at least a dozen or so ways the clan can annex you into it, at which point your life is more or less theirs, or they can just claim you've dishonored them and demand satisfaction. If they come through the treaties, then your friends can't help, not without calling down the Agency upon themselves."

Scary as Lillian's words were, they were made all the worse by the fact that I'd heard them before. That was almost exactly how Krystal had said it would go down, back when we were in Boarback and she'd first voiced her fears. I looked over at her and saw the sad resignation in her eyes. It was all coming true, just as she'd predicted.

"I've got a question," Arch interrupted, his hands twirling a cigarette between his fingers. Charlotte let him smoke in his room, but had banned it in public areas, especially where food was served. "Why are you telling us all

this? Shouldn't you be scampering back to your leaders and letting them know the skinny on Fred?"

The . . . skinny? Sometimes I forgot how old Arch really was. But before I could comment on his word choice, Lillian gave her reply.

"If that's what you really want, I can. Or I can pretend things are going fine. Doesn't matter; sooner or later, they're going to find out the truth. Petre is nothing if not thorough. He won't stop digging until he finds the source of those amazing vampire rumors, and from the sound of things, there are certainly enough dots to connect him to Fredrick." She halted, running a pale finger along the rim of her glass, creating a high-pitched whine. "As for why I'm giving you the heads up, I suppose I sort of like the idea that one of our kind can actually form relationships based on genuine affection. In the House of Turva, the only worth you have is how useful you are. After over a century of dealing with that bullshit, I wouldn't mind seeing them take a failure or two."

"Are all clans like that?" I asked. Though my question was directed at Lillian, it was Arch who answered.

"Vampire clans are organizations, and they work in different ways, but most of them have some form of hierarchy and need to keep people productive. Inter-clan conflict is almost a staple in the vampire world, so those who don't shore up resources and numbers are leaving themselves open to takeover. The only thing that keeps them from building an army are the clan-size limits in the treaties, and, obviously, the conversion rate issue."

While I wanted to ask about what the heck Arch meant by "conversion rate issue," Krystal added on to his speech and steered my mind quickly away from the topic.

"Some clans are better than others. The Turvas are just especially aggressive, dickish specimens," she explained. "All of them come with strings and rules, though. That's why we built a condition into the treaties that exempts all vampire agents from their clan's authority. If we didn't, there would be no end to the special treatment and favors they'd be obligated to provide."

"Bad or not, they do offer protection," Lillian added. "Protection that you don't have, Fredrick. My advice would be to abandon Colorado now, before anyone else puts this all together. We'll be here for a long while, so as long as you leave the region, you should be fine. They might send a runner or two after you, but with an agent at your side, I hardly expect that to be an issue."

"Damn right, it won't be," Krystal concurred. She turned in her chair, laying a hand on my shoulder. "Freddy, you said that if you needed to run, you would. I hate to be the voice of caution, but it sure seems like if there was any time to skip town, this would be it. I can have the jet prepped within a few hours."

“Albert, Neil, and I would only be a half-day or so behind you,” Arch added. “And I assure you, they would be well protected until they reached Boarback.”

“What about Bubba and Amy?” I asked. “And Charlotte?”

“Amy Wells is a respected mage and student of the King of the West,” Lillian told us. “The clan has no way to come at her that would not invoke retribution. Same for Bubba Emerson, employee of Richard Alderson, whom we must keep in our good graces to survive.”

“As for me, I’m a fortress,” the waiter spoke up, earning a sideways stare from Lillian, who still didn’t know the true nature of the home she occupied. “I could easily keep a whole clan of vampires at bay, if they even decided to attack me. Which, honestly, seems unlikely. You already saved me, Fred. It’s time to save yourself.”

“From the mouths of magical houses,” Krystal muttered. “We have to go, Freddy. You heard Lillian. There’s no way they won’t come for you.”

No, actually, that wasn’t quite right. What she’d said, what lay at the core of all of this wasn’t the fact that I was a vampire. It was my being an unprotected vampire. Quinn the traitor, my sire, had screwed me once again by creating me as an abandoned vampire. But there might still be a way to keep myself—and my friends—safe, while staying in the town I considered home.

“What if . . . what if I joined a vampire clan?”

# An Accountant in the City

## 1.

There were, admittedly, flaws in my plan, issues that Krystal was quick and vocal to make clear. Aligning myself with a different clan of vampires might solve my current problem, but it would undoubtedly open me up to a whole slew of new ones. No clan came without costs, and to throw in with one would mean owing allegiance to people whose goals and ideals didn't always line up with my own.

Arch was the one who pointed out the more pragmatic issue: vampire clans weren't often keen on taking outsiders, and we would be working with a limited time frame. Even if Lillian hid what she'd learned from her people, sooner or later there would be a target on my head, and if I hadn't negotiated protection by then, I would be out of luck.

Lillian, who I'd expected to be at least a little supportive of the idea, turned out to be my staunchest opponent, insisting that it was better to run as a free vampire than seek shelter in the cage of a clan. Her metaphor, not mine. The fact that she was the only one of us who was actually part of a vampire clan wasn't lost on me; yet, all the same, I couldn't bear to let the idea go entirely. Once I did, all that remained was running, and while I'd never had any issue with fleeing from danger before, something about this occasion just stuck in my gut. I couldn't explain it, but the idea of abandoning Winslow, of starting a new life in Boarback, seemed intolerable. Which was strange, all things considered, because I'd really liked our vacation there.

Eventually, the bickering wore down as dawn approached. It seemed prudent to get some rest and think things over. Arch and Lillian went to their own rooms, while I followed Krystal up the stairs to hers. We dressed for bed in silence, slipping out of our night's clothes—stained with blood and soot, respectively—and into comfortable pajamas. Keeping a small stash of clothes in her room had begun as a precaution and was quickly turning into a frequently needed asset. Sliding under the covers, I reached for her, but found she'd taken a perch near the edge of the mattress.

"Why are you doing this?" Her tone wasn't one of gentle concern, or frustration, like I'd been expecting. No, I'd heard Krystal pissed off enough to know what her anger sounded like, and there was quite a bit of it in her demand for explanation.

"I just don't want to leave town if I don't have to," I said.

"It's just a place. Buildings and streets and shitty, overpriced restaurants. Our families don't live nearby. Neither of us is even from here. I know you'll

miss the friends who stay, but life means starting over sometimes. I've had to do it a lot, and no one was trying to kill me. So tell me, really, why the hell are you being so stubborn on this?"

"Honestly . . . I'm not even sure I know." Despite the fact that the room was dark, I could still see the ceiling perfectly as I stared up at it from the soft bed.

"Do you think it's brave? That refusing to budge is manly? Because it's not. It's self-destructive, and pig-headed, and damn it, that's *my* job in this relationship. I don't need someone who is unwilling to bend. You're supposed to be the sane one, Freddy. The one who makes the calls that are actually good for us." Despite the fact that her fury seemed to be growing, she scooted a bit closer to me, away from the bed's edge.

"I don't think it's brave at all. I know it's stupid, that I'm being stupid, but I just . . . you were wrong a few seconds ago," I said. "About us not having family nearby. We have Bubba, and Amy, and Charlotte, and Richard and Sally, and even Gideon, if you count him as the scary cousin with tattoos and a rap sheet. Yes, Albert and Neil would come with us, but we'd have to leave so much behind. Resetting our lives for a good cause or each other is one thing; I don't want you to think for a moment that I wouldn't be willing to do that. But I've never had something like this before. A community. A family that genuinely cared about each other. The idea of leaving it all behind is more than I can stand."

Krystal moved closer, wrapping her arm over my chest. "It's harder to run away when you have to actually leave something behind."

"Guess I never had anything worth missing before." I pulled her in close, holding her in the darkness that never seemed dark to my altered eyes. "Am I totally off base with this idea? Be brutal with me. If it's just going to cause everyone more pain, if it will leave us worse off, if you say it's a lost cause, then I'll let it go."

"You will?"

"I trust you, Krystal. With my life. And no one knows more about this stuff than you do—at least, no one in my social circle. Well, except maybe Arch, but he's got his own desires to look after. The point is, if you tell me there's no hope in coming out ahead on this, then I'll believe you. We can catch the plane to Boarback after dusk."

Instead of the expected and immediate barrage of reasons why that idea was idiotic, Krystal greeted my request with a long pause of silence. Most who knew Krystal Jenkins operated under the impression that she was impulsive, and that was a very accurate impression indeed. What many people missed, however, was that when a decision truly mattered, she showed more care with it than anyone else I'd ever encountered. That was why I didn't object to the silence as she thought the problem through; I merely listened to

the sound of her breathing from a few inches away.

“Joining a clan just to stay in Winslow is an overreaction,” she finally began. “You’re taking way too big of a jump to handle a problem that could be solved with just a sidestep of location. But the truth is that you’re ageless now, Freddy. There will be more problems in the future, and running might not solve all of them. Belonging to a clan of vampires actually would be helpful in a lot of ways down the line. You understand that the act of joining opens up a myriad of problems all its own, but the clans thrive for a reason. At least as a member, you’d only have to deal with one clan’s bullshit, instead of every House of Whatever that wants to hassle you.”

“So, joining up now might not be worth it for dodging the Turvas, but it could pay off overall in the long run,” I summarized.

“Maybe. You don’t age, but I think we’ve both been around the block enough times to know that that doesn’t mean something else couldn’t knock you off the mortal plane.” Krystal laid her hand on my chest, just above where my undead heart lay. “Though I’d make sure whoever took you regretted it, I’ve seen too much death to think even I could prevent it. No one is promised an eternity, Freddy. No one knows how long they get. You might be trading some wonderful years down in Boarback with me for kissing the ass of some vampire house’s leader and scampering about at their every order.”

“You do know how to make a compelling case for Boarback,” I admitted. “But that seems like a worst-case scenario. We have a little time, here; Lillian said she’d keep the truth a secret for now if I asked. How about I at least do a little research into the vampire clans and see if there’s one who aligns with my own general sentiments?”

A hot wash of air splashed over my chest as Krystal snorted. “Freddy, vampire clans are notoriously tight-lipped about what they do and what their long-term goals are. They file exactly the paperwork the treaties demand each year, and no more. Everything they can conceal, they do, from the Agency and from other clans. You can’t just look that kind of shit up on the internet.”

“Oh. I guess I just assumed someone would know something. I mean, Arch always seems to have the inside track on everything.”

“When you’ve been around as long as him, you’ll seem that way too,” Krystal said. “But he’s still an agent, which means he has way too much on his plate to keep up with the scheming and regime changes of every vampire clan out there. We have some analysts who do monitor what they can in that area, but pretty much all of that is confidential.”

“Well, crud. There goes my brilliant idea of doing research.” I gazed into the depths of the ceiling’s tilework, wondering if I’d be able to get Charlotte a contractor to do updates from Boarback. With no way of knowing who I’d be throwing in with, my idea seemed dead in the water. I was willing to take



some risk to stay near my friends and business, but blindly joining up with a vampire organization was a step too far. I might just as easily throw in with someone as bad as the House of Turva, if not worse.

“There might be one person who can fill you in, but you won’t like it.” Krystal muttered the words slowly, like she was pulling them out of her mouth by sheer force of will. “Someone who was around when the treaties were created, and got a sense of every clan’s leader at the time. Someone who keeps an ear to the ground for schemes and rumors, and isn’t beholden to any sort of confidentiality agreement. If he’s willing, he could probably give you at least a basic understanding of most vampire clans.”

Dense as I could sometimes be in regards to all things parahuman, the dots of this suggestion were large enough that even I could connect them. So far as I was aware, I only knew one person who was alive when the treaties were signed, which is to say, when America itself was founded. And he certainly would have been a part of the process, given the title he still held. Plus, since he was watching over a therian child, he would assuredly keep his ears perked for any sudden ambition or regime changes, lest they find their way to Winslow, Colorado.

“I have to go talk to Gideon,” I said, trying to think of another option and failing miserably.

“Told you, you wouldn’t like it.”

## 2.

To say that Gideon and I had a complicated relationship would probably imply a familiarity that wasn't actually there. The first time we met, I'd fallen under the sway of his draconic aura, as all vampires did, and become a terrified, catatonic mess on the floor who'd had to be physically hauled out. The second time, I'd been kidnapped along with Sally Alderson, and he'd given me a single drop of his blood so I could withstand the aura and get her to safety. Our third meeting was the strangest, though, in which I'd slipped into a magical cage surrounding him and become a vessel for his magic so he could break free, all in order to stop the dragon who'd taken his place. That last one had actually been the most awkward of our encounters, and not just because it left me with the silver immunity as a side effect.

No, what had made that experience so strange was that, in conducting Gideon's power, I'd gotten a sense of just how strong he really was. If the draconic aura had conveyed how scared I actually should have been in our first meeting, I probably would have never recovered and instead just spent my undead life as a weeping mess on the floor. Knowing that power like Gideon's even existed terrified me in a way that went beyond fear of death. It was the first time that I'd understood just how great the divide between myself and the King of the West truly was. Powerful as vampires might be, we were still just augmented humans. Gideon was a living force of nature.

Some part of me suspected he knew what I'd seen, which was why Gideon had been absent every time I visited Richards in the months that followed. Perhaps it was out of deference to the fact that he didn't want me to give in to fear, or maybe he just didn't feel like dealing with me clumsily trying to kiss up lest he smite me with a thought. Whatever the reason, when I dialed Richard that afternoon and asked for a meeting with Gideon, I fully expected to be rebuffed. Even if he wasn't avoiding me, Gideon was still the King of the West; he had every right to tell me his time was worth more than my petty requests.

Which made it all the more surprising when Richard told me that Gideon would see me at ten, after Sally went to bed. I should have been relieved—this meant my plan still had a bit of traction—and a small part of me was. It was just dwarfed by the far vaster side that was terrified at the realization I'd booked a meeting with an ancient dragon to ask his advice on which vampire clan I should try to join. My best hope was that he found it amusing and didn't take offense. Otherwise, the whole issue of my safety could become very moot, very quickly.

As the sun was nearing the edge of the horizon, Krystal and Arch came downstairs for our nocturnal version of breakfast, followed by Lillian a few minutes later.

“What’s on the docket for tonight, boss?” she asked. She wore the same outfit as before, though it had been cleaned and pressed since she went to bed. Charlotte’s laundering skills were like the rest of her hospitality abilities: flawless.

“Don’t you need to head back to Petre and report on me?” I asked.

Lillian rolled her eyes while helping herself to the plate of eggs one of the Charlotte-waiters had set down in front of her. “I’m supposed to be covertly investigating you, remember? Wouldn’t make much sense for me to run back to the clan every night. They’ll be expecting me to hang around for at least a few days, worming my way in and getting the account details. I’ve probably got three more nights, this one included, before I need to report back and make sure things look like they’re on track.”

“Lillian, I wanted to ask you this last night, but there wasn’t quite the opportunity,” Arch said, exercising a lot more diplomacy than I usually saw from him. “If you cover for Fred, pretend you didn’t realize he was the vampire Petre’s hunting for, will there be consequences for you?”

“Oh yeah, Petre’s going to be mad as hell,” Lillian confirmed. “Even if he believes me that it was an accident, that’s the same as failure in the House of Turva. They’ll probably keep me off blood for a week or so as punishment.”

It took her three bites of eggs before she realized we were all staring at her in silence. Lowering her fork, she let her practiced smile shrink by several degrees, if not fall away entirely. “It’s okay. This isn’t the first time I’ve disappointed my sire, and it won’t be the last. I’ve had to go a month without blood in the past, so a few weeks is nothing. Sometimes, they punish me for things way beyond my scope of control. I’d much prefer to take this one for something *I* decide is worthwhile.”

Though I heard her words, my mind was still reeling. A *month* without blood? More than two or three days and I would feel the thirst, and within hours, my body would begin to ache as the cravings grew stronger by the minute. During those first days, before I’d lined up my supplier, the most I’d made it was four days, and I could already feel the beginnings of my sanity fraying at the edges from the endless thirst and pain. I didn’t want to imagine how much worse it got from there. Two weeks would have been a living hell. A month was more than I even wanted to wrap my mind around.

“Is there any way we can help you? Make it seem like this wasn’t your fault?” I asked.

“Fault doesn’t really matter. They just have to punish someone when there’s a failure,” Lillian replied, clearing off the last of her eggs moments before the waiter came through the door with a fresh plate for her. “Make an

example for the rest of the clan. The House of Turva hasn't exactly kept up with the times in terms of motivational strategies. Like I said, though, it's fine. Far from my first time dealing with this."

"Maybe that's true, but it's certainly not fine." I did some mental math, thinking through what I was trying to accomplish, and how much time I'd need. Probably weeks, if I were to do things properly. Though, if properly meant someone else being punished for my longshot idea, it seemed I would have to cut a few corners. "In three nights, when it's time to report back, I want you to tell them the truth. That I'm the vampire Petre is looking for, that my accounting service is just an accounting service, all of it."

"You're giving up on the joining a clan thing?" Lillian asked.

"Not quite yet. I've got a meeting tonight that might shed some light on the viability of it. Regardless, I won't let you take the punishment for helping us. If I can't make it work in time, then that's on me, not you. Go back to the Turvas as a successful infiltrator. That's the very least I can do to thank you for all of your help."

"Freddy," Krystal said softly, "you do remember that trying to join a clan is already really hard for an outsider, right? Even if it were doable, you'd probably need weeks to convince them to take you on, jumping through hoops to prove you were worth a slot."

"If it's already nearly impossible, then trying to do it in three days instead of a few weeks probably won't alter the odds that much," I told her. "Chances are we'll still end up on a jet to Boarback. I just want to see this through."

I realized that Lillian was the one who'd fallen into silence this time, examining me carefully from her spot at the other end of the breakfast table. She'd even stopped eating, and was just pointlessly poking her eggs with her fork as she mulled over my words.

"If that's really how you want it, Fredrick, then I'll give them the rundown in three nights. But if you change your mind before then, just let me know. I made the offer, and I meant it; I can buy you more time."

"I greatly appreciate the sentiment, but I'm afraid the price on that offer is simply too high." Chancing a look at my watch, I realized that with the sun setting, I'd need to head out soon to make my meeting. While there was plenty of time until ten, Charlotte Manor was located some ways from town, and getting through the ceremony and security at Richard's office always took longer than I expected. Even after all my visits, they were still wary of letting a vampire into the heart of a therian stronghold.

"Beg everyone's pardon, but if you'll excuse me, I need to go get ready to head out," I announced, rising from the table, my own food barely touched. Even Charlotte's cooking couldn't settle the case of nerves I was dealing with.

"Just let me finish off this plate and I'll be ready to go." Lillian bent down closer to the table, fork in prime egg-shoveling position.

“No need, take your time and enjoy the meal,” I advised her. “I’m going to have to leave you behind for this meeting.”

“That’s probably not going to fly,” Lillian said. “Remember, I’m supposed to be your new assistant, your shadow, following you at every turn. What do I tell Petre if one of the clan sees you out on the town without me?”

“The truth,” I replied. “That I was going to have a meeting with the King of the West. By now, they know enough about Gideon to be aware that he wouldn’t tolerate a tag-a-long in one of his meetings.”

“And if they ask how you’re able to meet with him despite the fact that vampires can’t handle their draconic aura?” Lillian pressed.

“Right . . . I forgot they knew about that.” With everything on my plate, it was getting hard to keep track of how well-informed my opponents were.

“We just moved to a town with an ancient dragon; it came up in conversation,” Lillian said. From across the table, I saw Krystal chuckle, and for a moment, I even thought I caught a smirk on Arch’s face.

“Tell them Freddy dealt with a proxy.” With her giggles dying down, Krystal had apparently decided to be helpful. “That’s how the dragons dealt with vampires in the old days; they had a representative come stand in their place and have the conversation via telepathy enchantments with the proxy. Nowadays, most just use Bluetooth and a cell phone, but the tradition remains for the rare times when a dragon meets with a vampire. And since the proxy is essentially the dragon, you’d still have to show it the same respect by not bringing an intern along.”

“Trainee,” Lillian corrected.

“Spy, if you want to be a dick about it,” Krystal shot back.

“Right then, let’s just say I dealt with a proxy.” Something told me that if I didn’t right the conversation to a more productive path quickly, it might spiral beyond saving. “Lillian, will that sell upstream?”

“Don’t see why not, though maybe it’s best if you just try not to get spotted by any other vampires,” she suggested. “The less I have to talk to Petre before it’s decision time, the better off you are.”

“Well, I’ve managed to spend most of my life slipping around unnoticed,” I said. “Maybe just this once, it can be an asset.”

“Personally, I think it’s the sweater vest. Who pays attention to someone wearing a sweater vest?” Though Krystal was the one to speak the words, it didn’t escape my notice as I left the dining room that everyone else at the table seemed to be nodding along in agreement.

### 3.

To my surprise, when I arrived at Richard's building, I wasn't shown up to his penthouse/throne room at the top like usual. Instead, I was frisked by therian security, who glared at me stonily while checking to ensure I hadn't brought any weapons with me. This pat-down was far less extensive than usual, I noticed, probably because while a firearm might be an issue for Richard, all it would do to Gideon was annoy. When security was finally done, I was taken up a different elevator than the one I normally used, to a floor that looked familiar—though all the generic office floors seemed that way. I was escorted down a hallway, coming to an office near a corner, and I suddenly realized exactly where I was before the door had even opened.

This was the room where Gideon had been held captive several months earlier. Where Bubba, Amy, and I had hunted him down, breaking into the magical cage while therians from another tribe slammed on the door, trying to kill us before we could free him. Even if I hadn't been able to place the dull gray carpet and open layout, I certainly recognized the broken remains of the cube where Gideon had been trapped. They were there, just as I'd last seen them when fleeing the building. All that was different was that now a desk and a few chairs were set up in front of the twisted metallic remnants of a trap strong enough to ensnare a dragon.

Sitting behind the desk, drawing in a coloring book, was Gideon, whose child-like appearance belied the tremendous power and knowledge resting inside him. The door whispered shut behind me, and I realized that the therians had left me alone in the room. Not even they liked to be around Gideon any more than was strictly necessary. Since I didn't have the luxury of fleeing, I decided to say something and start things off. Given how nervous I was, I hardly think I can be blamed for grasping the easiest conversational option available.

"I thought you'd have cleared that out by now." I nodded to the massive remains of his cage, as if he didn't know what I was talking about already.

Setting down his crayon, Gideon looked up from the coloring book with a stare meant to scrutinize. It was unsettling to see on a child's face, though I was slowly getting used to that effect when dealing with Gideon. It beat his aura any day of the year.

"Interesting." Slowly, Gideon hopped off the chair, raised to its highest so he could see over the desk, and approached me. Every step was tentative, as if he thought I might bolt should he move too fast. Eventually, he got within a few feet, close enough that I could reach out and rumple his hair, were I so

suicidally inclined. “This has already proven to be a fascinating meeting. I wasn’t sure you’d be able to withstand my aura anymore.”

“Why wouldn’t I? You gave me your blood,” I reminded him.

“Indeed, and far more than a drop on that night.” He gestured absentmindedly to the cage’s remains, never taking his eyes off me. “But from the reports I received, all that power had been used up, burned through in my escape. The effects of such gifts are temporary, as you must know by now. Even the drop I gave you would never have lasted so long, were you the sort to actually use your abilities. When the draconic power in your veins is tapped out, so too should go your immunity to my aura. Yet here you stand, unbothered by my presence.”

“I do still find you very intimidating,” I said, not sure if I was trying to reassure Gideon that I was still meek and cowardly or that he had more than enough mojo to be terrifying.

“That is because you are a being of logic,” Gideon replied. “Of course you fear what is stronger. Nonetheless, this makes for a fascinating study. Never has a blood-eater tasted so much of a dragon before—at least, not a dragon of my power—nor have they been used to wield their magic. It seems there are some lingering aftereffects, aside from just the ability to dine with proper silver.”

“You knew about that?”

Gideon turned and walked back to his desk, motioning for me to follow. “You saved me that night, Fred. Not my life, no, but certainly my pride. And, more importantly, perhaps you even aided Sally by freeing me. True, I am not the kindest or most cuddly of creatures in the world, yet even I see fit to look in on those who have done me a good turn. I even agree to take their meetings, if I’m curious enough.”

“And I appreciate that,” I said, taking a seat in one of the open chairs in front of the desk. Again, my gaze slipped to the cage, and I could see Gideon’s violet eyes tracking my own.

“I keep it here to remind anyone I meet with how futile it is to try and go against me,” Gideon said, offering the explanation to my opening question. “Almost none know of your part in my escape that night, which makes it all the easier to build my reputation. Defeating another elder dragon’s carefully constructed trap is no small feat, and the name of Gideon has only grown more feared since I accomplished it.”

“Do you really need intimidation tactics? I mean . . . you’re *you*.” That was, sadly, the best way I could think to phrase my thoughts in the moment. I didn’t want to fall over myself and gush; besides, we both knew I’d seen how deep his well of power went. The idea of using intimidation tricks felt like ridiculous overkill.

“Strong as I am, there are others out there who are my equal, if not my

better,” Gideon said. “Though these methods are not for them. Should we ever clash, the very landscape of the Earth would be changed, which is why we all tend to avoid each other as much as possible. No, I keep it here for the smaller threats, the nuisances. So many that would waste my time and their lives never do, simply because I show them the futility of such actions. Power is useful, Fred, never doubt that, but far more useful is the perception of power. I’ve lived a very long time, and I can say with certainty that the easiest fights to win are those that never start.”

Since Gideon had just offered me the perfect segue, I hurriedly leapt for it, determined to make the most of my time with him. Curiosity had gotten me in the door; there was no telling how long it would keep me there.

“It’s interesting that you bring that up, because I asked to meet you for essentially that purpose. I’m sure you know about the arrival of the House of Turva in Winslow—”

Gideon’s mouth pinched into a visible sneer, so I raced forward before he could cut me off.

“—and they’ve become interested in me as either a subject or a rival. Since I’m an abandoned vampire, there are many ways for them to come at me through the treaties, so I thought it would be worthwhile to look into joining a clan of my own. But no one knows a lot about them and their inner workings, except perhaps you, so I came here seeking counsel about what you knew of the various clans.”

The sneer had faded as I got further along, turning back to the same scrutinizing expression I’d seen when first walking in. He was searching me for something; though, what it was, I had no idea.

“Fred, do you believe that you and I are equal?”

“Absolutely not, sir.” My eyes widened, and I momentarily faced the very serious possibility that this might be my last few seconds of life, undead or otherwise. Offending a dragon like Gideon was not the sort of thing many lived to tell about. “I am keenly aware of how much more powerful and important you are, and I’m so sorry for wasting your time with my request. It was a move of pure desperation, and—”

“I think, perhaps, that something was lost in translation here.” Gideon was still calm, which wasn’t as reassuring as it should have been. I had no doubt he could kill me without any emotional fluctuation whatsoever; the only thing I’d ever seen rile Gideon up was Sally’s safety being threatened. But he also hadn’t made any aggressive movements, and that was somewhat more heartening. “What I mean is, do you believe we are equal for the turn you did for me in this very room? That my debt to you is paid in full?”

“Oh . . . then yes, I do. Our bargain was fulfilled. You asked for freedom, and I asked you to save my friends. We both honored the agreement, so I didn’t think there was any debt between us.”



Gideon's eyes, for the first time since I'd met him, fell a few inches toward the ground, almost like he was a bit embarrassed by something. "You are incorrect, both on what I swore and on the topic of our equality. Though I accepted it in the heat of the moment due to limited time, the truth is that, that deal was not a fair one. I asked more than I gave, and while dracolings may take pleasure in such slights, we dragons hold ourselves to a higher code. Stealing, pillaging, ransacking, all of that is fair game, but in our bargains, we always seek to find equilibrium. There is still some debt between us, Fred, and that is the real reason why I took your meeting. I despise inequality, and I would like to remedy it as quickly as possible. So then, would you like me to take care of your problem?"

"That's why I came here," I said, no doubt visibly relieved. Gideon wanted to pay me back and I wanted to pump him for information, so this would work great for both of us.

"No, you came here for a temporary measure that would only incur more trouble for you. I'm not offering to tell you about the blood-eater clans. I'm offering to solve your problem. These creatures stepped foot in my town, and no doubt, they are scheming all manner of mischief. It will be little more than a slap on the wrist for me if I wipe them out."

And that was when I finally realized what Gideon was actually offering. He would purge the entire House of Turva, kill every last one of them, just because he felt some debt to me. That was possibly the most terrifying prospect I'd ever heard, all the more so because I knew too well just how easily Gideon could do it. One word from me and by the morning sunrise, there would be no issues. No House of Turva. Likely, no other vampires would come to Winslow for a century or so after such a display. And, ashamed as I am to admit it, there was a fleeting moment where I wanted to let him do it. Take away all the fear, and worry, and stress these invaders had caused. Mercifully, it lasted no longer than a moment before reality came crashing back in. Even if I believed that this would really be the end of it—which I didn't—the guilt I'd feel over all those lives would utterly dwarf whatever issue I was dealing with currently.

"I'm grateful for the offer, really I am, but I think that might be a touch extreme. I'm sure the House of Turva has plenty of good people in it who don't deserve to die just because I was scared. Besides, there are only so many vampire clans, right? The Agency is bound to be a little miffed if you wipe one off the map," I said.

"It would get replaced eventually; every half-century or so, one ballsy blood-eater founds a new clan that actually manages to stick around. But it is not my place to dictate how I repay my debt," Gideon said. "If information is what you want, then I'll give it. Just know that this does not fully settle things between us. Perhaps you'd care for another few drops of blood?"

“Thanks, but no thanks. Your power is way too potent for me to handle. I kept snapping things in half for a week last time I got a drop.” I hadn’t meant it as a joke, but I caught sight of Gideon snickering anyway.

“Very well, then just information for now. Though I doubt it will give you what you need, I shall tell you all I can remember of the various blood-eater clans dotting this county’s landscape,” Gideon said.

I yanked out a pen and pad of paper from my briefcase as Gideon started talking, jotting down every detail I could as quickly as he laid them out. There would be more questions later, when I knew enough to have an idea of what to ask about, but for the moment, I was content with simply absorbing a small bit of the ancient dragon’s expansive memory.

## 4.

“Twenty-eight active vampire clans in America, four of which were founded after the actual creation of the country and treaties. Of those, twelve have some pretty repugnant ideas about humanity as a whole and are kept in check only by the laws, which rules them out right off the bat. Two are pro human and vampire relations, but have a lot of bad history with therians. Three are openly about vampire superiority over other parahumans. And the other eleven are either too secretive or small to make waves in any direction, though there’s always a bit of scuttlebutt around them.”

I finished running down the list, pages of more detailed notes summarized into these simple bullet points. I’d spent all night and halfway through the morning talking to Gideon, cooped up in that windowless office as he went through exhaustive explanations of every vampire clan he could remember. It had been a disheartening affair, yet I pressed on regardless, sure that it would be the next clan he mentioned that would finally fit my needs. Eventually, he ran out of things to share, and I had Krystal come pick me up, since her truck was fitted with enchanted windows to block out the sunshine. Back at Charlotte Manor, I’d taken a big meal and spent hours reviewing the notes, looking for something, anything that I’d managed to miss.

“To be fair to all the respective houses of vampires out there, it looks like the core of Gideon’s knowledge came from when the treaties were being drawn up, and that was over two hundred years ago,” Krystal said. “There were a lot of unpopular opinions held by humans back then too, which have changed with the times. I’m sure some of these have grown at least a little.”

“Enough to where it’s safe to petition them for membership?” I asked.

“Oh *hell* no, are you kidding me? Jumping in bed with a clan you know next to nothing about is freaking crazy. Even if they’d make room in the quota for you.” Krystal, unlike me, was still eating, having decided that since she might be leaving Charlotte for some time, it was a good excuse to avail herself of as much cooking as possible. Currently, she was working on a half-devoured piece of chocolate pie, though I had no doubt it would fully vanish within the next few minutes.

“Right, the quota. You and Arch mentioned that last night. What’s the deal with quotas?” Even as I asked, I remembered another term they’d used, one which stuck in my head. “And for that matter, what does ‘conversion rate issue’ mean?”

Krystal set the fork she had partially raised to the side of her plate, my first clue that I’d touched on something more serious than I realized. “Quotas

are straightforward. The treaty limits how many vampires a clan is allowed to have at any given time. This is based mostly on how long a clan has existed, though it does cap out at a certain point. It's part of how we ensure that the need for blood never outpaces the supply. Conversion rate . . . well, that's the reason vampires didn't manage to take over the world before the treaties. The truth is, being turned into a vampire is far from a foolproof thing. Of the humans that vampires attempt to turn, a shockingly small amount actually make it over."

"Do I want to know?"

"Since actually testing it clinically would require killing a lot of people, the Agency has never done formal research, but based on what we've learned from the older clans, our best guesses put it at a little less than one in every ten," Krystal told me. "No one knows what makes the difference; it goes across all genetic markers that we can find, and seems to hit male and female equally. Just a lottery that gets played with someone's life on the line."

"Wait . . . that can't be accurate." Already my memory was whirling, back to when Lillian had told us a small bit of her history with the House of Turva. "Lillian said she was turned just to seduce some politician. Why would they do that if there was a good chance she'd die?"

"Because they didn't care." Krystal's tone was so blunt it could have fallen from her mouth and cracked a wineglass. "Vampires are allowed to try and turn a certain amount of people each year—that's how they reproduce, so it was well worked into the treaties—but that comes with knowing about the failure rate. And back then, things were messier, less organized, so not everyone kept to their numbers like they should have."

I sat in silence for a long moment, staring at my stack of notes, waiting for some solution to pop out at me. "Just when I think I couldn't possibly want to be affiliated with these people less, I learn more about them, and suddenly, it's all I can do not to run screaming into the night."

To her immeasurable credit, Krystal resisted the urge to say that she'd told me so, picking up her fork and turning her attention back to the pie instead. I let her eat as I perused the notes, slowly realizing with each turned page that my hopes were growing dimmer. Logically, my best bets were the four newer clans, formed after the treaty, but if membership was limited by seniority, then my odds of getting in with them were all the slimmer. Not to mention, I was assuming they would be more akin to my way of thinking, since they were newer, but I also had the smallest amount of information about them, which increased the risk of me choosing poor allies.

"What's the quota for new clans?" I asked. It was a pointless question that would lead nowhere, yet I asked it all the same. Some part of me, it seemed, was determined to examine every avenue of this idea, regardless of how fruitless I already knew it to be.

“Not a hundred percent sure,” Krystal said. “I’m pretty sure it’s ten to start, then ramps up for the first few decades, and after a century, the rate slows down a lot. You can always check the books, though. That would definitely be in them.”

She had me there. I was just being lazy with my desperation. Slipping my laptop out of my briefcase, I woke it from hibernation mode and pulled up one of several saved PDFs on the hard drive. Though Charlotte Manor now had excellent Wi-Fi, I’d been left without signal one too many times not to keep these tomes saved locally. To a layman, these documents merely looked like material for the most boring role-playing game on earth. *Spells, Swords, & Stealth: Modern Justice* was ostensibly a court-like tabletop game notorious for its insanely complex rules about parahumans living in the modern world. In truth, it was the actual bible of treaties, laws, and revisions which governed the parahuman part of our country. Hidden in plain sight, where anyone was free to see it, in what I always considered to be one of the Agency’s more cunning moves.

Though I usually occupied myself with the books regarding accounting law, a close call—in fact, one inside Charlotte Manor—had shown that it was worthwhile to keep all of the books on hand, just in case. After a few wrong files and a quick search, I finally found what I was looking for. The actual laws about founding new clans were surprisingly lean, and it took no time to skim down and find the information about quotas.

“Looks like new clans get capped at ten parahumans—wait, that can’t be right. It should say ‘vampires.’”

“They tried to keep the language as generic as possible, just in case we ever hit a snag,” Krystal explained. “There have been a few vampire offshoots over the centuries—mages experimenting and creating things that were close, but not quite, vampires. Since ‘parahuman’ is a word that covers everything, most of the treaty uses it wherever possible, just in case we get some surprises down the line.”

“That is an impressive amount of foresight,” I said. “Anyway, they get ten spots at their founding, then they get another five slots after twenty-five years, another five at fifty, then five more at seventy-five years, and one last group of five at a hundred. From there, they gain ten new slots every fifty years for the next two centuries, and then ten every hundred for a millennia.” My brain quickly did the math before I even noticed I was adding the numbers up. “So, the most any clan can have is a hundred and seventy vampires?”

“Sounds about right,” Krystal confirmed. “Though, of course, we’ve got the clanless ones to account for too, like those in the Agency, or abandoned ones like you. Still, you can see how precious those slots are, especially for the younger houses.”

“No kidding. A clan with only ten vampires would be crushed by the ones

with a full roster,” I said.

“There are some checks and balances for two houses dealing with one another, but yeah, not many of those last too long,” Krystal confirmed. “Starting a new clan generally means you either have real ass-kickers with a lot of connections and mojo, or you’re aligned with someone powerful enough to give you protection.”

“Seems to be the case.” I read through the document again, noting that although the limits on how big a clan could get were well defined, down to the parahuman, actually starting one was relatively easy. A new idea, built on the ashes of my old one, started to bloom. This was insane, obviously. Completely so. Even worse than my first idea. But . . . it couldn’t hurt to do a little research. Could it?

“If Lillian wakes up, let her know I’m on the phone,” I said, rising from the table.

“Calling the Sheriff to tell him we’re heading down?” Krystal asked.

“Not quite yet.” My fingers were already flipping through my phonebook as I sought out the familiar name of an old friend. “First, I need to talk to a lawyer.”

## 5.

**\*\*Note: As I was not present for what occurred next (I was busy in a meeting with Asha to further my own plans), I must allow another to momentarily take up the tale. In this case, Charlotte was chosen, as she has both an excellent memory and a knack for seeing more than most.\*\***

Strictly speaking, it is not the place of a house to interfere. We exist to offer shelter from the storm, warmth from the cold, and a sense of security to those staying within our walls. That is the philosophy of all proper houses, even if some aren't as keenly aware of it as I. And that is the directive I was created with, when those mages empowered and enlightened me all those decades ago. So I said nothing as they drove themselves deeper into madness and greed, courting an inevitable death at the hands of angry agents. I merely did my duty, filling their bellies with food and wine, keeping the beds neatly made, and stopping any who might intrude.

Then the agents came, with cunning plans and stronger magic. And I sat alone for a very long time, ensnaring any stray guest I could just for a small semblance of company, something that could remind me of when I'd been more than just a house, I'd been a home. It was a lonely stretch that I can scarcely look back on without my windows growing foggy. But on the day when someone proposed my very destruction—what should have been the worst, possibly even final, evening of my life—salvation arrived. Fred protected me, gave me the rights to my own property, and for that alone, I was grateful. But then he went and did something I'd long given up hope of ever feeling again: he gave me purpose. First Arch, then Krystal, and, bit-by-bit, laughter and conversation filled my empty halls for the first time in so long I could barely withstand it, I was so happy. There was a reason to burn the candles again, as he and his friends routinely came for dinner or lodging.

It is not the place of a proper house to interfere. But I am not just any house, and I have had my rooms emptied before. That is not something I wanted to experience ever again. So perhaps that is why, when Fred ran out the door with Lillian in tow and Krystal called my name, I came to her, ready. That shrewd look on her face left no doubt of what she would want from me, and despite all the notions of decorum and privacy I knew I should maintain, I put up no resistance as she asked for it. I materialized in the form they thought of as the real me, a lovely young woman in a gown I'd seen and fancied on one of my residents. It was as good a form as any, and I somewhat enjoyed the sense of familiarity in her eyes as I appeared at her summons.

True to form, she wasted no time in getting down to business.

“What was Fred talking to his lawyer about?”

“Based on what I could overhear, it seems he’s decided to take a new approach. Rather than just joining an existing clan, I believe he intends to found one of his own.” Though I couldn’t make out Asha’s words through the small phone—so much tinier than the rotary versions we once possessed—Fred had been the one doing most of the explaining.

Krystal sucked in a sharp breath through her teeth and let it out as an equally sharp whistle. “Fuck me, that’s what I was afraid of. He had that look in his eye, you know? The one where he thinks he’s cracked the problem. I was hoping it meant he’d given up, but with what he just finished reading . . . shit. Shitty shit, shit, shit. This isn’t good.”

“It does seem like it would remedy the issue, does it not?” I’d dealt mainly with mages and elderly couples between my creation and bed-and-breakfast days, so vampire society was not something I had extensive knowledge of.

“Only in the most technical of senses. A clan with one member is no better than an abandoned vampire in practicality. He’s far from the first of his kind to get this idea, and there’s a reason so few new clans survive. There are plenty of ways within the treaties for the houses to squabble with each other.” She stared down at the empty plate in front of her, and for a moment, I considered having another part of me bring out more pie. I hesitated, though, as Krystal was generally one to make it clear when she wanted something.

“There’s probably no stopping him, either. When he gets these ideas, it’s like all the smart parts of his brain just shut down.” Krystal reached into her pocket and yanked out her own phone, thumb racing across the flashing screen. “Charlotte, I hate to impose, but would you mind putting together some dinner and coffee? You’re going to get an influx of guests in the next hour, and I’d like to soften them up with some good food, at the very least.”

“Of course. Let me know when you’re ready for the meal to be served.” I vanished then, though that was merely for her benefit. Though they rationally knew that I was everywhere at once within these walls, the act of seeing some specter or other tends to unnerve people. Perhaps they felt they weren’t being watched if they couldn’t see the eyes. Not that they had anything to worry about; a proper house knows the value of silence and decorum. With forgivable exceptions where the safety of one’s guests are involved.

Over the next hour, I opened my doors several times to many familiar faces. Neil and Albert were the first to arrive, the latter courteously wiping off his shoes and urging the former to do the same. Then came Amy, who stared up at me as she entered, no doubt examining the spell work that wove through every beam and stud of my being. Bubba was next, and along with him, I was surprised to see the massive Richard ducking down to fit through my door frame. I wondered if I had any rooms big enough to accommodate him,



should the meeting run long, and then resolved to fix that lack of hospitality as soon as possible. Arch made his way down from his room eventually, having finished the paperwork he'd been dealing with for several hours.

With the last of the guests present, I began serving the soup course, as Krystal brought everyone up to speed on Fred's predicament. Most knew the basics, but between clarifying questions and recaps, I was putting down the fish course before she was done telling them about the latest twist, that it seemed Fred was trying to form his own vampire clan.

"Well, that's surprisingly stupid," Arch noted, as one of my waiter selves filled up his water glass. A cigarette was being rolled between his fingers as usual, but though I kept watch, I never caught him breaking our lease agreement. Once I had the time, I was hoping to add a smoking lounge for those with small nicotine sticks or old-fashioned pipes like my creators had smoked.

"I'm sure he thinks he's got some angle on it; Fred's rarely one to overestimate himself," Krystal snapped defensively. "But, this time, he's biting off more than he can chew. If he tries to meet the House of Turva on even ground, they'll tear him apart. Worse, they'll see it as a sign of aggression, and that makes our plan to disappear more complicated."

"Sheriff Thorgood can more than handle one clan of vampires," Bubba pointed out.

"True, but he shares the same weakness we do—come through the treaties, and he may have to back down," Arch countered.

"If you think Leeroy Thorgood is backing down from anyone trying to hurt his residents, you don't know him that well," Krystal said. "No, my concern is that eventually Fred will want to leave Boarback. Maybe for a trip; maybe for somewhere new to live. Whatever it might be, if Fred creates a grudge between himself and the House of Turva, then they'll lie in wait until opportunity strikes. Boarback is supposed to be our refuge, not our prison."

Slowly, Albert raised his hand in the air, waiting to be called on. Eventually, Krystal noticed and gave him a small nod. "Maybe he won't be able to pull it off so soon. If I've learned anything working for Fred, it's that paperwork can take a long time to go through. You said he has only two nights left, so time might fix the problem for us."

"Much I wish I could believe that, having seen Asha and Fred work together up close, I've got no doubt in my bones that they'll find a loophole or expedition clause or somethin'. Nobody knows paperwork like those two," Bubba said, shaking his head gently.

"I could petition to block it, since he'd be founding in my town," Richard volunteered. "That might slow them down enough to force the issue. I hate to do it, but if it's for Fred's own good, then it would be the right call."

Krystal drummed her hands on the table, considering the proposal. "Too

risky,” she said at last. “Even if you can block him, the Turvas might still find out he tried to form a clan. At that point, he’s in just as much shit, but without even the thin veneer of being part of a clan to protect him.”

“It is possible to render the discussion moot.” Neil had been uncharacteristically silent as he listened to the issue’s discussion, his eyes glancing over to Albert on occasion, and Amy more frequently. “Fred and I haven’t always gotten along well, but I don’t want to see him killed. So, what if I were to bind him like that night at the LARP? Grab him as soon as he comes back in, leave him catatonic, and then put him on a plane.”

“I don’t think Fred would care much for that,” Amy told him.

“Oh, no question about it, he’d likely despise whoever did it to him, which is why I volunteered,” Neil said. “We’re already on poor terms; it doesn’t really matter as much if Fred hates me. I can even pull it off alone, so that the rest of you have deniability.”

Though I said nothing, Neil’s plan did seem to have some merit to me. It kept Fred safe, minimized risk, and kept the backlash limited to one person. Those thoughts stayed with me as I cleared plates and readied the steak, however. It was not my place to intrude.

“I am not proud of how tempting that offer sounds.” Krystal pushed her empty fish plate away and reached down, pulling up a thin device that I’d learned was a tablet, which essentially seemed like a big version of those new phones, except that it didn’t make any calls. “The truth is, I do have something of an idea on how to help Fred. Not to stop his gambit, to make it actually work. But, and this is the part that I know makes me a shitty person, I can’t be a part of it. I have to ask something huge of you all, while I can’t do the same.” She pressed a button on the side and the tablet’s screen began to glow as my waiters made their way to the back.

“Charlotte, can you send one of the staff over here or just show up yourself?” Krystal called, looking around the ceiling like I was going to suddenly pop out. “This concerns you, too.”

My dress-clad form appeared near her, ready to serve my guests as always. “What can I do for you?”

“Pull up or create a chair, I guess.” Krystal tapped her screen gently. “I want to get your feedback on the plan, even if you don’t choose to join in.”

My form shuffled uncomfortably, a bit of my feelings accidentally leaking through. “Respectfully, I’m not one to usually give feedback. I make contracts with guests and fulfill them. I keep my residents safe and comfortable. That is the duty of a house.”

“Well, this time, I’m going to ask you to make a choice,” Krystal replied. “This won’t be a request, or a contract, or any of that. But depending on how things go, this might change a lot of stuff. For you, and for your current guests. You deserve the right to have some say in it.”

I said nothing, merely nodding slowly while, in the kitchen, my waiter selves materialized food. I should have been in there, shapelessly watching over them, not out here dealing with matters that I likely had no real right to involve myself in. A proper house was silent, stoic, and took no action in its residents' lives.

But, as I was slowly discovering, I was not such a proper house as I might once have thought myself. And if it meant my halls were not forcibly emptied again, I could find a way to deal with that. So I sat and listened as Krystal outlined her idea, which seemed, by all accounts, just as—if not more—crazy than Fred's. I didn't say that at the time, of course.

After all, that would have been impolite. Besides which, I was far too busy falling in love with the half-mad idea.

## 6.

**\*\*Note: As this chapter starts after both my own meeting and the one I was, at the time, unaware of, I will resume the telling from this point. Suffice it to say that unless you have a deep and abiding fascination for the complexities of paperwork, there is little being skipped over that would be worth recounting. \*\***

Lillian and I made it back to Charlotte Manor less than an hour before sunrise, having pushed our time with Asha to the utmost limit. The hours flew by as she and I worked to make something impossible into a reality, all while Lillian pitched in with her experience from being part of a clan. We made our way in through the door hurriedly, noting that the sky was already growing light, only to find the elderly version of Charlotte—the one I considered the greeter—waiting for us.

“Hello, Fred, Lillian. Can I prepare anything for you?”

“I wouldn’t say no to some steak and coffee,” Lillian replied, without a moment’s consideration. “After watching Fred and his lawyer go through paperwork all night, it’s going to take a little caffeine to keep me perky past sunrise.”

“I’m on it. And for you, Fred?”

“Some light fish, if you have it,” I told her. “And wine. I’d very much like a nice glass of red. Are Krystal and Arch around?”

Charlotte shook her head, her hair not swaying in the slightest as she did. “They were both called away shortly before you arrived. Neither offered their destination, and I find it best not to pry into the business of agents.”

“Can’t say I disagree with that policy.” Lillian let out a long yawn and stretched, putting her arms overhead like a pale cat reaching for the ceiling. It was a gesture I’d grown quite used to during the past several hours, as she’d had no qualms about demonstrating how bored she was while Asha and I poured through stacks of laws and documents. That said, her help had also been invaluable, as the only one among us with practical knowledge of vampire clans.

The old woman lifted an ancient phone, ostensibly to put a call into the kitchen, and I knew that the moment we sat down in the dining room, dinner would be served. I tried very hard not to think of it as a last meal while Lillian and I made our way down the hallway. It wasn’t, after all, even by the most pessimistic of standards. There was still one more meal to eat, regardless of how things played out afterward. It would be, without question, the most

uncomfortable dinner party I'd ever hosted, but by necessity, there would be food. What came after that, however, was completely up in the air. I'd done my very best, and chosen to take a gamble that at least had the potential to see me through.

While Charlotte's waiters brought out our drinks and dishes, I found myself wishing Krystal was there. There hadn't been time to consult her while Asha and I tried to determine what was even possible, and then how to accomplish it, but now that things were settled, I'd have preferred to get her up to speed. True, most of the dice were already cast, though a few could perhaps still be altered with a fast enough call to Asha. Honestly, though—and I feel awful admitting this—part of me was also glad that Krystal had been called away. Despite it being my best odds for survival, I knew she wouldn't entirely agree with the path I'd taken. When it mattered, she would support me, just as I would her, but that didn't mean I wouldn't get a long chewing out when everything was on the table.

For the moment, at least, the only table I had to concern myself with was Charlotte's, and that one was currently hosting our entrees, along with a cavalcade of sides neither of us had shown the presence of mind to request.

"You know, even with this place being haunted, the service is freaking incredible," Lillian commented, as she dug heartily into her rare steak. The need for blood in her beef wasn't vampiric in origin; Lillian simply appreciated a quality meat cooked only enough to add flavor, not steal it away.

"Charlotte Manor is the best kept secret in Winslow," I said, knowing full well that Charlotte was listening. "My only complaint is that the prices are too low. For food and service this excellent, I really wish she would charge a fair amount."

"Money is useful, but it's not the goal of our establishment," one of the waiters, usually silent as a church at midnight, said politely as he topped off my wine glass. "We see our rewards in other ways."

Which was the same argument Charlotte had used before when I encouraged her to increase her prices. It was a long-running discussion we'd had many times since I took up the role of her business manager. One day, I hoped to break through to her, but she could be surprisingly stubborn on certain issues. Then again, houses weren't exactly known for being easy on the budget, so perhaps I was at fault for being surprised she had dug in so hard.

"Would you please let everyone know that there will be a dinner party tonight?" I told the waiter. At this point, keeping Lillian in the dark about Charlotte's true nature was a matter of time rather than secret-keeping—the explanation just took too long. "We'll invite guests to join us at eleven, so please have refreshments on hand for . . . ?" I stopped, looking across the table to Lillian, who began doing quick math on her fingers.

“For a meeting like this, Petre will come, and he’ll want to bring some muscle under the guise that they’re assistants and lawyers, but he won’t want to seem like he’s walking in ready for war, just in case. With Petre included, no more than four would be my guess. Add in you and me, that makes six. Then there’s Krystal—”

“No more than six,” I told the waiter. “Much as I would like to have her around, I’m almost certain that bringing an agent to a meeting like this comes with all manner of implications. Krystal is my girlfriend, but she is also her job. It’s not my place to drag her into this situation. Plus, having an agent at the meeting would be a bit like showing up at a negotiation and setting a loaded handgun on the table. It lends an air of inauthenticity to any advocacy of peace.”

“Not even going to invite your other friends?” Lillian asked.

I picked at my fish, moving my fork slowly from side to side. “More of the same. It pulls them into a problem that isn’t theirs. Like I said before, my friends aren’t assets, and I won’t treat them that way.”

“Then you better really hope this gambit goes well,” Lillian replied. “It’s a new one, I’ll give you that, but Petre doesn’t usually care for surprises. For what it’s worth, I’m pulling for you, even if I won’t be able to actually help if it all turns to shit. It probably won’t, though. Petre prefers to be more methodical than just murdering someone at dinner.”

“Thank you. It’s worth quite a bit, actually. I never would have made it this far without your help.” Lifting my glass, I exchanged a brief clink with Lillian’s coffee cup. It was strange, knowing that someone I was quickly growing to consider a friend would stand idly by if I was being torn to shreds, but I understood. My research into the world of clans had done nothing if not show me just how dangerous vampire society could be. I’d barely managed on my own for a few years, and that was only through the help of my amazing friends. To face that world completely alone, without any sort of aid or clan backing her, would be akin to a death sentence.

“So, just to be clear, you’re sure you want me to put in the call during the day?” Lillian asked. “If we wait until nighttime, Petre can still make it over easily. During the day, though, there’s the slim chance that he might hire some non-vampire goons to come try and solve the problem.”

“Despite the quaint looks, Charlotte Manor is extremely difficult to break into,” I assured her. “And it’s a small risk. I’m just asking for a meeting, after all. Petre seems like the business-minded type. I think he’ll want to show up and see what I’m offering before he decides to try and kill me.”

Since the time for Lillian to check-in was almost at hand, we’d decided that she should come clean about what she’d uncovered. Today, while the sun hung overhead, she was going to call in and report all about how she’d realized I was the vampire from the rumors, though the rumors had been

exceedingly misleading. She'd also let Petre know that I was requesting a formal meeting with the House of Turva, though I ostensibly wouldn't tell her the exact details of what it concerned. At that meeting, I would lay everything out for Petre. If it worked—which I was pinning all my hopes on the prayer that it would—the night would end peacefully and I'd be able to remain in Winslow.

If I failed, then I might get killed, and even assuming I survived, running would be the only recourse left. Albeit, not in the way that Krystal had initially proposed.

Lillian finished off her meal and coffee, and then rose from the table. "All right, I'm going to go try and yank all the paperwork discussion out of my head before making the call. If anything goes off-plan, I'll knock on your door and let you know."

"I'd greatly appreciate that." As Lillian left the dining room, I polished off the remainder of my fish and picked up the wine. Though the sun would be rising soon, and I should get as much rest as possible for the coming night ahead, I found myself with no inclination to close my eyes just yet.

Charlotte emerged from the dining room in the form I considered to be her true one, even though it was no more real than the waiters she had scuttling about. Moving delicately, she took a seat at the head of the dining table and turned her attention to me. "Going to bed?"

"Not quite ready," I told her. "I think I'll try to wait for Krystal to get back."

"She might be gone for some time," Charlotte cautioned me.

"That's all right. I have almost nothing else to do. All the pieces are in motion now; until tonight, I have no real part to play. Oh, except . . ." I reached down for my briefcase, popped it open, and pulled a business card from its depths. Sliding it across the table, I waited until Charlotte had picked it up to continue.

"In the event of my death, whenever that may come, I've made arrangements for Asha to manage your business until such time as a suitable replacement is found. She would come by to explain everything if the occasion arose, but I felt like you should hear it from me, just so you knew she was on the up-and-up. You can trust her."

"Didn't I hold this woman hostage and threaten to kill her?" Charlotte asked.

"Water under the bridge. Well, mostly under, anyway. Regardless, she agreed to take on the responsibility, and that means she'll see it through," I assured Charlotte.

"Thank you." In a motion, the card vanished, though I had no doubt it was tucked away safely somewhere inside the expansive estate. "You didn't need to worry about me, you know. There's already a lot on your plate."

“It’s really nothing, something I should have gotten done ages ago. Most of my clients can find new accountants, but I’d be doing you a disservice if I left you in the lurch.” I took a long drink from my wine, and behind Charlotte, a waiter appeared with a fresh glass in hand.

“Please do your best to survive this dinner party,” Charlotte told me. “I’ve got no desire to get accustomed to working with someone new. Plus, cleaning all the blood off my floor would be a real pain, even for me.”

“Have no fear, I plan on doing everything I can to survive the night.”

That seemed to satisfy her, and we sat in silence for some while afterward. I went through three more glasses of wine while I waited for Krystal to come bursting through the door, yelling about some out of control parahuman she and Arch had brought down. She would be loud, and messy, and total chaos, and I wanted to see her like that again. Just once more, before it all came to a head.

Eventually though, I gave up, heading upstairs and climbing into bed alone.



## 7.

The paperwork was sitting on the bed, messengered over midway through the day. The dinner was being prepped, not that most of the diners would be touching it, and the clock was ticking down, with less than half an hour left until my guests arrived. And yet, I was stuck, fumbling with a tie I'd knotted countless times, my fingers so dumb with nerves that I couldn't manage to get the cursed thing properly around my neck. All I could think of was the impending meeting, the clan of vampires on their way to Charlotte Manor, and with every passing second, my longshot seemed less and less likely to succeed. It was like my hands knew it, and were purposely refusing to finish the knot, keeping me from going downstairs and facing my own execution squad.

At least the rest of my suit was pressed and ready; the delivery service Asha recommended had really been top-notch. I didn't own a lot of suits; they were mostly used when I went to formal occasions or courted more professional clients. Still, like any good entrepreneur, I had a few, and I'd been wearing ties for the vast majority of my adult life, which made it all the more frustrating as I sat in the bedroom, still alone after a day of waiting, trying to figure out where I kept going wrong.

"Someone is feeling fancy tonight."

I jerked my head around. In my preoccupation with the tie, I hadn't even noticed the door slip open, let alone the familiar face it had revealed. Krystal stood there, in the same clothes I'd last seen her in, bloodshot eyes betraying the fact that her assignment had kept her up all day. I didn't care in the slightest as I rushed forward and embraced her. Deep down, I'd begun to grow truly afraid that I might not get to see her again before the dinner. While I didn't actually think Petre would kill me outright this evening, it was a risk, and if it happened, then my greatest regret—aside from getting murdered—would have been not getting to tell Krystal goodbye.

"Yeah, I missed you, too," she said, from deep within my tight hug. "Sorry, day's activities took a lot longer than I thought they would."

"It's more than fine." Pulling her through the door, I closed it, and then allowed our bodies to part. Much as I wanted to hold her, getting her up to speed was the first priority. "There's so much to tell you, and not much time to do it. Firstly, the House of Turva is sending—"

"Petre, who Lillian told all about you, and you boys are having a formal sit-down to discuss the new situation." Krystal grinned—that wildcat smile that spoke of danger and secrets not yet seen. "Who do you think you're

dating? I've got my ear to the ground about everything that even thinks it might have fangs right now. And yes, that includes your Hail Mary with Asha, too. I'm fucking air, Freddy. I'm everywhere."

"So . . . you already know everything?" I plopped onto the bed, a sudden rush of anxiety leaving my body. I'd been bracing for this all day, nearly as much as the meeting itself, and she'd already found out everything on her own.

"You, my little overreaching boyfriend, decided to found your own vampire clan. Thanks to a lot of loopholes and paperwork, you even managed to gain temporary authorization until a full review can be conducted. Still, it's enough to give you some treaty protection for now, and you're hoping that will be enough to keep the House of Turva at bay."

"Actually, there's a bit more to it than that," I said.

"Geez, Freddy, I told you I'm in the loop. Do we need to sit here and hash out every freaking detail? By my count, you've only got a little bit until your guests show up, and you should be ready to meet them when they arrive. Don't start something this important off by slighting another clan." She leaned down and poked my poorly knotted tie gently. "And what's with all this get-up?"

"You've seen me in a suit before," I reminded her.

"Yeah, for the job, or when we went somewhere swanky. Why are you dressing up for these shitbags?" Her hands moved quickly, pulling apart the tie's interwoven areas until it hung limply on both sides of my neck once more.

"I thought it would be only proper. I want to show them respect."

"This isn't a business meeting, Freddy. It's a pissing contest. Don't try to impress them, make them try to impress you. Dress in a way that's comfortable, familiar, and lets these bastards know exactly who you are." Krystal yanked the tie off, crumpled it up, and tossed it into the corner.

"You think I should stick with the khakis and sweater vest?"

"If it ain't broke, don't fix it." She leaned in, kissing me firmly and running her hands through the hair I'd just recently finished combing. "Go meet these people as yourself. That's my advice. And I hope you'll take it, since we both know you're about to insist I not join you for dinner."

"Did Charlotte tell you?" I rose from the bed as I spoke, beginning to unbutton the crisp white shirt and eyeing my closet for something with a bit more life to it. I'd long ago brought a small stash of clothes, given how often I slept over at the manor, and it was preparation that paid off as I surveyed my choices.

"She offered to serve Arch and I meals in the sitting room, so that was a bit of a tip-off," Krystal replied. "By the way, I accepted the offer, but he didn't. If this is a formal meeting between the representatives of two vampire

houses, an agent has the right to sit in and bear witness. That should make sure things stay peaceful, and Arch has a long-standing reputation for remaining fair and unbiased, so they won't have any room to bitch."

"Will Petre be okay with that?" I found a light blue cotton button-down and tossed it over my torso.

"Who gives a shit? Part of the fun of being an agent is getting to swing our dicks around when the occasion strikes. It's all in the treaties, so Arch is allowed to be there. Which means if Petre has an issue, he'll take it up with Arch, and no vampire lives to be that old by being stupid enough to pick that kind of fight."

With the shirt on, I swapped out my dark suit pants for khakis, and then topped it all with a gray sweater vest. I did feel more comfortable, more like myself, and it seemed to have helped with the nerves. Turning to face Krystal, I held out my arms and did a quick spin. "How do I look?"

"Like Freddy. Like the man I love. Like someone who's going to make it work tonight." Just like that, she was across the room and kissing me once more, though this time, she left my hair alone.

"You're really okay with all of this?" I asked once more, just to be certain. "It's going to change things, you know."

"Aren't you the one who told Albert about how everything changes, and sometimes, it makes our lives a lot better?" Krystal reminded me. "I'm not super thrilled with the plan overall, and I've got a plane on standby if it's needed, but I'd be lying if I said I wasn't a little impressed. You went to all this trouble, just to avoid running."

"It wasn't that I didn't want to run," I told her. "I just didn't want to leave so much behind."

"Well, then, get your cute ass down there and go fight for your town." She smacked me on the butt and pointed me toward the door. "Oh! And Charlotte is doing place settings; make sure you get the seat designated for you. I left you the extra special cutlery, just in case."

"You realize this is supposed to be a peaceful discussion, right?" I asked.

"Freddy, if you don't come ready for war, then you'll never manage to bargain your way to peace. Now scoot, I've had a long day, and I need a shower. When it's all wrapped up, I'll come join you, and we can go from there." With that, she disappeared into the attached bathroom, shutting the door firmly behind her.

I took the cue and headed downstairs, two envelopes of documents tucked securely under my arm. With a brief detour to the dining room to drop the papers off at the seat with a white placard bearing my name, I headed to the front hall, where my guests would soon be arriving. Lillian was already there, as was the old woman version of Charlotte. The former was wearing a new outfit, and she gave me a discerning glance as I walked in.

“Didn’t feel like dressing up?”

“This is a business meeting, and you’ve seen that this is how I dress for business.” Though I expected to feel a wave of self-doubt over the fact that I’d gone too casual, I actually weathered the comment decently. Krystal was right, feeling centered with myself and who I was mattered more than impressing these people.

Arch stepped in from outside, the lingering wisps of cigarette smoke still clinging to his form. “Looks like your guests are here. Three in the car that’s pulling up, no idea if more are lying in wait on the road.”

Though, from most people, such thoughts might have seemed paranoid, with Arch, I knew it was just him thinking tactically. He strode past us, on track for the dining room, where he’d no doubt be waiting to oversee the meeting. It was quite comforting, actually, to know he’d be there. I’d never really expected the night to devolve into violence—Petre seemed the type to be more cunning than that—but having Arch on hand made it all the less likely.

I stood as straight as possible while the three figures made their way up the porch stairs, finally pushing through the front door. Petre was flanked on either side by thick-necked vampires dressed in impeccably tailored dark suits. They were tall and strong, likely nurtured by a healthy diet of therian blood. Despite the size difference, Petre himself still stood out the most, his pale blue eyes taking in every detail, like he was deciding which nearby knick-knack would be best suited for killing us all.

“Mr. Fletcher, a pleasure to see you once more. I trust your new employee is working out well?”

“Quite well. She’s been a tremendous help, and I think she’ll only grow more useful as she’s trained.” We exchanged bows, and I looked to the hulking slabs of undead muscle near him. “And may I ask your friends’ names?”

“They are unimportant, only here to assist me with details. Please, ignore them. I try to whenever possible.” Petre smiled, his fangs just the slightest bit extended. He was enjoying this, and didn’t mind letting me know. I hoped he kept his good humor when the situation changed. “I must say, Mr. Fletcher, I’ve been doing my research, and you are quite the interesting character. Tell me, what do you consider a higher honor, having won the esteem of a dragon, or having bedded an agent?”

“Ah, right, the rumors. Those do come up on occasion. That’s part of why I called you here for a meeting. But how rude of me, let’s head to the dining room. No point in standing about the hall when there’s comfort and drink to be had.” I motioned down the hallway, hoping I’d kept the temptation to sneer at him off my face when he talked about bedding Krystal. This was the game I had to play if I wanted to win the right to stay in my town. I wouldn’t let

him beat me so soon.

The night was just beginning, and I had a few cards of my own to surprise him with.

## 8.

To his credit, Petre waited until the drinks were poured and a plate of appetizers was set on the table before getting down to business. Somehow, a part of me doubted he'd have shown such courtesy if Arch hadn't been sitting there, helping himself to the bruschetta while the rest of us stewed in anticipation for what was to come. Once the agent was eating, however, Petre clearly felt the time had come.

"I'll be brief, Mr. Fletcher, as I'm sure you have much to do with your evening. Having learned what we did about your incredible achievements over the past few years, the House of Turva has decided to do something we'd previously ruled out: offer you membership in our clan." Petre held out a hand, and one of the nameless goons sitting to either side of him slipped a large piece of paper into his fingers. He set it down and slid it expertly across the smooth wooden table, where it halted inches from my plate.

"Feel free to look things over—and that goes for you as well, good agent—the pertinent information is all there. We extend this as an olive branch to one who has been left alone for too long. However, as an abandoned vampire, you have little means to refuse the invitation. We wouldn't want fear of something new to make you miss out on such a wondrous opportunity." Petre smirked, a small gesture that wasn't even properly suited for the amount of gloating he obviously wanted to do. No doubt, he expected this to be an easy win. Maybe he even hoped to walk out tonight with his new pet accountant—taken right out from under an agent, no less.

"It is a very kind, generous offer," I replied, careful to keep civil. I was pushing my luck more than enough without adding a personal grudge to the mix. "Unfortunately, I must refuse it. Renowned as the House of Turva is, I'm afraid the invitation comes a bit too late. You see, I am no longer an abandoned vampire. I've already joined a clan."

Petre's small smile receded back into his sour expression as I reached under my chair and pulled out my first envelope of documents. Rather than slide it like Petre had, I merely held it up, allowing one of the waiters to take it from my hand and walk it over to the other side of the dinner table. Petre snatched it and ripped open the top, eyes darting down the pages as he took the information in. I used the brief moment of silence to take a deep gulp of wine from my glass. This next part was going to require all the fortification I could muster.

"Surely this is some poor attempt at humor." Petre dropped the documents carelessly, as though he could no longer bear them sully his fingers, and

several slipped from the table to the floor below. “A temporary authorization for a one-person clan? That is what you would choose over the millennia-old House of Turva?”

“I’m really more of a modern vampire anyway, not much for older styles,” I replied. Not exactly the most neutral way to decline, but it was hard to tell someone you didn’t want to join their club without hurting their feelings in one way or another.

“This is preposterous.” Petre’s eyes danced to his muscle, who stirred at his gaze, but then his attention turned to Arch and the activity came to a standstill. He calmed himself, looking back at me and speaking with forceful intention in every word. “Let me tell you something, Mr. Fletcher, as I’m sure you didn’t truly understand what you were doing. Founding a clan is not something to be done lightly. Even assuming you correctly jump through all the hoops to be recognized under the treaties, what you have done is form a new a clan in territory currently being controlled by another, much larger house. The agent here can attest that such situations are very rarely amicable, and there are no shortage of treaty-sanctioned ways for us to deal with a rival on our territory.”

Petre paused, waiting for Arch to say something, either in agreement or disapproval. Instead, Arch merely nodded to a waiter for more water, staying devoted to his role as overseer and refusing to get unnecessarily involved.

“I’ll give you one more chance, Mr. Fletcher.” Petre wasn’t even hiding behind the veil of civility anymore. He leaned forward halfway from his chair, and as he spoke, I caught sight of his fangs, further extended than they had been in the hallway. “Throw off these ridiculous notions. Submit to the House of Turva now, while the doors are still open to you. Or is it truly your intention to fend off an entire house of real vampires with a clan consisting solely of yourself?”

And here it was, time to hit him with the sucker punch that would determine whether or not this plan was a total bust. “As a matter of fact—”

“As a matter of fact, you’re bad at counting, fuckface.” Krystal’s voice rang through the dining room, cutting me off and causing Petre’s goons to start in their chairs. She was no longer dirty or tired; in fact, she seemed to blaze with a light all her own as she strode into the room. Her rough boots stomped on Charlotte’s wooden floors, and the gun belt strapped to her hip jingled slightly with every step. I’d seen this Krystal before, only in fleeting glimpses, but it was unmistakable for any other version of her. This was Krystal in full-on, ass-kicking-agent mode.

“Who in the nine hells do you think you are, interrupting a private meeting?” Petre motioned to the goon on his right, who started to stand. A very audible click filled the air, and all eyes turned to Arch, who’d produced a gun and had it expertly trained on the vampire halfway out of his chair.

“I’m going to have to insist that you not make any aggressive moves toward an agent. For everyone’s safety.” With his free hand, Arch helped himself to the last of the bruschetta, and a waiter whisked away the plate as if there wasn’t a gun suddenly out at the table.

“Sit down,” Petre hissed to his muscle, glaring at Krystal with a sudden influx of fear. A few seats over, Lillian grinned, taking a sip of her wine for the first time. She obviously couldn’t meddle or show me support, but the sudden appearance of Krystal had caused all our controls to slip a bit.

“I see, so you’re Mr. Fletcher’s lover.” Petre seemed to be regaining his self-control. He did know how to roll with the punches; I had to give him that. “Then, as an agent, you’d know that you are not permitted to interfere in conflicts that adhere to treaty conditions. Bluster about all you want, but if you so much as put a toe out of line in defending this one-vampire clan, I’ll have your badge.”

“First off, there’s a lot of shades of gray in those treaties, and you shitbags aren’t the only ones that can use them.” Krystal leaned forward, stopping inches from Petre’s face. Whatever aura of confidence and intimidation he’d spent centuries perfecting was wasted on her as she met his sneer with a grin. “And secondly, I just told you that you counted wrong. Freddy’s not the only member of his clan.”

“Ahem. Um. Is that my cue?” We all turned to find Albert, standing in the dining room doorway, talking to someone out of sight further down the hall. Evidently, he received an affirmative answer, because he stepped forward and looked the entire dinner party in the eye, one by one. “Fred—I mean, Mr. Fred, also has me.”

“Am I expected not to notice that’s a zombie?” Petre asked. At this point, I think he was temporarily more confused than anything else, which made two of us. While I’d certainly come to the meeting with a crazy, long-shot plan, this hadn’t been part of it. So when Krystal began to explain, I was paying just as much, if not more, attention than my adversary.

“Notice all damn day if you want. We checked the treaties up, down, and sideways. Any newly founded vampire clan has ten parahuman spots. It’s just that none of you ever bothered using them for anything besides vampires.”

“Why would we?” Petre turned from her to me, clearly under the misimpression that I was in on this spectacle. “Is that the best you can do? Padding your ranks with a mere zombie?”

Two heavy footsteps were the only warning we got as a new figure arrived in the doorway, this one far less concerned with protocol. Neil was decked out in a full set of robes, similar to the ones I’d seen the mages wear during Albert’s fight with the chimera—though his were darker, and he clutched a black tome in his thin hands. From how tightly he gripped the book, it was clear he was annoyed, even before he began to bark at Petre. “Watch your



mouth, or I'll make you rip your own tongue out."

In a few steps, he'd joined Albert by my chair, resting his free hand on my assistant's shoulder, near where the top of Albert's sword poked up. "This 'mere zombie' happens to wield the Blade of the Unlikely Champion. Show some damn respect." He paused, apparently remembering that he was supposed to do something other than just stick up for Albert. "Oh yeah, and I'm a member of the new clan as well. And no, I'm not a vampire, either. I'm a necromancer. I'm the puppet master who can pull all your undead strings."

"You align yourself with the ones who can control us. How desperate are you, Mr. Fletcher?" Petre asked.

"I mean . . . honestly, right now, I'm a lot more confused than I am desperate," I admitted. My eyes turned to Krystal, even I as heard heavy footsteps making their way to the doorway. "What is going on here?"

"I told you I was in the loop," she said, unabashedly savoring the surprise on my face. "It was easy to figure out. And when I talked it over with everyone, they agreed that this was doomed to fail if it was just you. So we decided that if you were willing to go to this much trouble to stay with us, then the least we could do was have your back. Officially. Well, they can. I'm an agent, so we're not really allowed to belong to any organization."

"But . . . but I didn't want any of you to be drawn into this." Now that I finally understood what was going down, my mind was reeling, so forgive me if perhaps my word choice wasn't quite as keen as it should have been.

"We know you didn't. And we know you'd never ask us to do somethin' like this. Which is prolly the exact reason we all agreed to." Bubba's thick, deep voice resonated from the doorway as he walked into the room. "And for y'all in here who don't know me, I'm Bubba Emerson. Therianthrope and currently a member of the tribe led by Richard Alderson."

"This is getting beyond ridiculous," Petre snapped. "A therian cannot belong to a clan and a tribe at the same time."

This time, when the footsteps echoed, there was no mistaking their owner. Bubba might leave a hefty boot print, but no one in the room, or probably the city, carried the same kind of bulk as Richard Alderson. He ducked his head to step through the doorframe, and suddenly, the entire atmosphere seemed to change. Up until then, I'd have guessed that Petre considered himself to be dealing with annoyances, something he'd have to pick apart later. Richard, however, was a peer. This man wielded most of the power in Winslow, power the House of Turva very much didn't want turned against it.

"As it turns out, parahumans can belong to multiple organizations, assuming the leaders of each permit it," Richard told the room. "I personally signed my agreement to Bubba's dual status this afternoon. Fred, you have any objections?"

"I'm just trying to keep up at this point," I replied. "But since it seems like

this happening with or without me, Bubba is free to be in both organizations, if it's what he really wants."

"Didn't think you'd mind," Richard said. "Also, Petre, though I obviously cannot join Fred with the others, you should know that my tribe has submitted an official mutual cohabitation and alliance agreement to Fred's new clan. I'm sure I don't need to tell you what that means if you decided to declare war on my friends."

"I also wouldn't count on the mage community for much support, unless you're playing nice." Amy had wandered in, practically unnoticed by any of us amidst the sea of vast personalities already present. "Since I joined the clan too, I reached out to a few friends in the spellcasting community. As of now, anyone on unfriendly grounds with my people can go elsewhere for all their magical needs."

Petre was fuming, unsure of who to stare more angrily at, though I was certainly getting the most frequent bout of his attention. "And who the hell is this woman?"

"That would be Amy Wells, sir. I mentioned her in my report." It was the first time Lillian had spoken since we sat down, and from the barely suppressed mirth on her face, I could only imagine how long she'd been waiting to slip a few words in, twisting the knife as she watched her superior lose control.

The rage on Petre's face seemed to dim. He glared at us, more sullen than furious now, bathing us in unmasked hatred. "This is quite the coup, Mr. Fletcher. You present yourself as such a caring, innocuous man, but when the moment arrives, it seems you have no trouble throwing the might of your allies around."

"Yo, dumbass, have you really not caught on yet?" Krystal snapped her fingers in front of his face, forcing him to look up at her. "Freddy didn't ask us for this. We snuck around behind his back, meeting with his lawyer as soon as he left, getting the paperwork sorted and everyone officially registered. He would never use us to scare you. We made that choice all on our own, and it's because we're not his allies. We're his friends."

"Technically speaking, as of now, we're also his family," Amy added. I noticed that tonight, in one of the few occasions I could recall, Amy had no strange auras, glows, or magical effects around her. She'd shown up stone-cold sober, which meant more than words would ever convey about how important she considered this evening.

"Fine, you're all friends, you're all family. It doesn't matter. The oldest of you is what? Perhaps a few decades old? I've been playing politics for centuries upon centuries." Petre rose from the table, his goons following suite. Only Lillian hesitated. "You think an alliance with a therian will protect you? Or a little inconvenience from the mages? I am beyond patient, and I will find

a way to gain retribution for this slight. And what will you do, Mr. Fletcher, when I strip away the protection of your precious family? How will fend for yourself when there is no one else to stand for you?"

"You know, I was actually getting to that, before my friends came charging in and did the most amazing, caring thing I've ever seen." It was my turn to stand, because, with the momentum on our side, I had a new idea, one I'd have never dared try before. But the night was going well, and all of a sudden, pressing that luck didn't seem quite so foolish. First things first, though, it was time to get my last card, what I'd thought would be my trump, down on the table.

"Feel free to come after me any way you see fit, Petre." I reached back under the chair and grabbed one last document, this one kept apart from the others for good reason. "Just know that, when you do, you're attacking more than just me. As of last night, Fletcher Accounting Services has officially signed on to do freelance budget auditing for the Agency."

## 9.

It was my turn to smile as everyone else in the room stared with unexpected shock at the revelation, which I actually found quite confusing. Some had wide eyes, others gasped, and Krystal was opening and closing her mouth repeatedly, as though she kept deciding what to say and then changing her mind at the last moment.

“What? You said you were filled in all the way. You’re the ‘fucking air,’ remember?”

“I meant I knew about you starting a vampire clan,” Krystal snapped, my prompt finally giving her a set of words to start with. “But you signed on as an *Agency* contractor? How did you even know that was possible?”

“You mentioned it when we were in Boarback,” I reminded her. “Said it came with a lot of perks. I did some digging and found out that that included a certain level of protection. *That* was my plan tonight. You didn’t all really think I was planning to keep a whole gang of vampires at bay just by starting my own clan, did you?”

“Did Asha know about this?” Krystal demanded.

“Sure, she’s the one who helped me put it through.” From the look on everyone’s faces, ranging from uncertainty to betrayal, I gathered it was something she hadn’t mentioned during their meeting. While she technically shouldn’t have, and given that she had let them all join my new clan in secret, I had a hunch that she’d have given them a heads up on the contractor thing if they’d asked. “Wait, did you all barge in declaring that you already knew everything and wanted to help?”

“Well, we let Krystal do most of the talkin’,” Bubba admitted.

“Still, even if I told her we were up to speed, you’d think she would have mentioned it,” Krystal mumbled. “Freddy, do you have any idea what you’ve done? Being connected to the *Agency* is not exactly all smiles and tickle-fights, even if they just want you to crunch numbers. The reason the job comes with protection is because a *lot* of parahumans hate us, and aren’t shy about taking it out on the people who work with us.”

“Indeed we do,” Petre agreed. Truthfully, in the moment, I think we’d all nearly forgotten he was even there. “Mr. Fletcher, when I believed you had turned your allies into pawns to stave off being absorbed into our clan, I thought you a manipulative, cunning bastard, but at least I respected that. Throwing in with the *Agency*, however, is an unforgivable decision. You would scamper under the protection of those that murder our kind, all for little more than accepting the nature we were born with.”

“We only kill the ones who break the law.” Arch hadn’t completely put his gun away; instead, it was resting near his dinner fork, one motion away from being swept up again.

“Petty, pathetic laws that we were strong-armed into agreeing with,” Petre replied. All the anger was gone from him now; in its place was cold, empty hatred. There was no question about it, I’d definitely made myself an enemy this evening. It was a terrifying thought that I would dwell on endlessly later. For the moment, however, I tried to focus on the fact that he probably couldn’t hate me anymore when I made my big move.

“Tonight, you have done more than slight the House of Turva,” Petre continued. “You have betrayed your own kind. To take the sacred tradition of a clan and allow the common parahuman riffraff within its ranks was bad enough, but to then cast your lot with the Agency just for a small modicum of protection . . . Fredrick Fletcher, you are no vampire to me.”

“You know, I think I’m okay with that,” I replied. “If being a ‘real’ vampire means being like you and your clan, then I’m fine being considered something else. Hell, I’ll take it as a compliment. Because here’s the thing, Petre: your kind of vampire might have a giant clan with lots of people to take orders, but as Amy pointed out, my kind has a family. If that’s the deal, then I’d rather be a failure of a vampire any day of the week.”

“Let’s see if you can hang on to that sentiment when the House of Turva begins picking you all apart.” Petre turned to the last seated member of his party and called to her. “The work is done, Lillian. Let us return home for the night. There is no longer any need to serve such a useless man.”

“Lillian, stay right there.” I spoke before she even had a chance to pull her chair back, keeping Petre’s attention on me. This was the part I’d been trying to build toward, the thing I’d wished for, but never would have had the courage to try without my friends filling the room behind me. “Not to be rude, but I believe Lillian was given to me as a gift of friendship. Or does the House of Turva often rescind its gifts when it suits them to do so?”

“We do when we no longer wish for any sort of friendship with those we were dealing with,” Petre snapped. “I am willing to leave here tonight peacefully, Mr. Fletcher. Do not test my generosity any further than that.”

Krystal actually laughed at that point, short and harsh and so emasculating that even I felt wounded by it, despite the fact that it was aimed at Petre. “Are you really trying to pretend that *you’re* the one who is choosing to resolve things peacefully tonight? Freddy might be naïve, but the rest of us can do the math. If you throw so much as a sharp look at someone in this room, the three of you would get beaten halfway to your final coffins. As for Lillian . . . hey, Arch, you know protocol better than me: what’s the deal with taking back an official gift of friendship?”

“Legally complex, and often varies case by case,” Arch replied calmly.

“It’s a tedious ordeal, usually more trouble than it’s worth for both parties. Still, if you both want to go down that route, I can make some calls to start the paperwork.”

“Or . . .” The idea poured from my mouth as fast as it formed, my eyes on the untouched place setting only a few feet in front of me. “We can settle it here and now, like real vampires. How about a test of strength, Petre? That should appeal to your proper ways.”

“You wish to fight one of us?” Though I’d expected him to be annoyed, Petre instead seemed cautiously intrigued. He was probably imagining getting to snap me in half while my friends looked on, but I had something different in mind.

“Oh no, nothing that barbaric. Besides, with the amount of parahuman blood in you, I know I wouldn’t stand a chance. I meant a much more personal, ego-driven strength. Strength of will. Krystal, do you or Arch happen to have any silver daggers on you?” I asked.

Without pause, Arch reached into his jacket and produced a gleaming silver blade. Everyone in the room (except Krystal and the mages) shrank back visibly, though my reaction was purely for show. Catching Petre’s eye, I nodded to the dagger resting in Arch’s hand.

“It’s a simple game. We take turns holding the dagger, and whoever can bear it the longest is the winner. No amount of blood either of us might have in our system is going to help with that.” Technically, my words were true, as the blood in my system had absolutely nothing to do with how this could play out.

“Let me guess, if I win, Lillian comes home, and if you win, she stays?” Petre asked.

“No,” I said, looking at Lillian past Petre’s glowering countenance. “If you win, Lillian goes with you. If I win, Lillian gets to choose what she wants to do. Maybe she’ll still go home to the House of Turva. Maybe she’ll ask to join my clan, which she’s welcome to do. Maybe she’ll want to be an abandoned vampire for a while and see how she likes it. But the decision will be hers to make.”

Petre chuckled under his breath, turning to meet Lillian’s uncertain eyes. “I think you ensnared this one too deeply, my child. He thinks to win you a freedom you don’t want. Very well, Mr. Fletcher, I will play your game. But I have a condition: we will need two silver daggers, and we shall hold them at the same time. This way, there is no dispute about who drops first, and neither of us has the advantage of a goal to beat. You might think me foolishly prideful, but I’m not so dumb that I think you’d choose a contest you didn’t have a good chance at winning. Perhaps your pain tolerance is abnormally high, or you simply believe in your heart that you can do it. Regardless, I will not give you any needless advantages.”

“I’d say that’s more than fair,” I agreed. “Arch, do you have another?”

The blade was in his hand before I’d even finished the question. Rising from his seat, Arch walked toward Petre, and I made my way over to join them. The rest of the room backed up, giving us ample space. This was as much because we were near silver as out of desire to let the contest occur uninterrupted.

“These blades are both silver,” Arch announced. “I’d like you both to briefly touch, smell, or do whatever you need to confirm that, just so there are no accusations later on.” Petre carefully touched his thumb to both daggers, showing no outward sign of pain, but keeping the contact brief. I did the same, though I made myself appear to be hiding a wince each time.

“I will lay these in your bare palms simultaneously. You cannot touch, bump, or in any way physically interfere with the other. The first person to release their grip on a blade is the loser. Any objections or questions?”

Petre and I both shook our heads and held out our hands. Arch didn’t bother repeating himself; instead, he laid the blades across our flesh, releasing his hands once we’d gotten a firm grip. The silver still tingled a bit as I clutched it, unlike a normal metal, but I wasn’t flooded with pain and weakness the way it had once affected me. Even being near the stuff had worn me down to near human levels; chains of silver over my clothes had held me more than once. Actual skin-to-metal contact had burned, like touching something that was just a bit too hot at first, but with every passing second, the pain had grown steadily worse. Silver-insulated magic interrupted it, and for a vampire, that meant being brought back to the corpses we truly were.

At least, that’s how it was affecting Petre. For me, it was just the tingle, nothing more. It was possible Petre hadn’t been wrong when he said I wasn’t a real vampire anymore. Whatever Gideon’s magic had done to me, it must have changed my body in a pretty fundamental way for silver to leave me unbothered. Being different wasn’t so bad, though. Especially not when it gave me the opportunity to help my friends.

To his credit, Petre held out for a full minute before his composure began to slip. The steady hand holding his blade wobbled first, by only a few degrees, then progressively more and more as his placid expression melted to one of focus and pain. His gaze wavered between his own hand, mine, and my face, where he found an utterly untroubled expression. If I was going to go to all the trouble to make an impression, I felt like it should at least be a strong one.

“You have . . . good . . . pain tolerance.” His teeth were clamped together as his hand shook violently. All of his instincts were undoubtedly screaming at him to throw away the dagger, yet he was halting them through sheer force of will. In that moment, I dearly hoped I never had to face off against Petre in a genuine contest. The way silver used to hurt, I couldn’t have managed what

he was doing for even ten seconds.

"I just have a really good reason not to let go," I replied, voice steady and calm.

"Even if you . . . win . . . she'll . . . come home."

"You think so? Maybe you're right. Why don't you drop the dagger, and we'll find out." The truth of the matter was that I didn't know if Petre was wrong or not. Lillian had certainly voiced frustration with her clan and the desire to not take their orders, but ours was still a motley lot to throw in with. She very well might choose to stick with what was familiar and at least relatively safe. But . . . they'd kept her from blood for a month before. That wasn't punishment, it was torture. If there was even a chance she'd grasp for freedom, I owed it to her. Without Lillian, I never would have gotten the time and intel to create my own clan in the first place.

Despite my words, Petre kept hanging on to his blade. Another minute passed, and then another. At long last, as his whole arm was shaking, Petre let the dagger clatter to the floor. He'd made it three minutes and change, judging by the antique clock hanging on the dining room wall. Honestly, I was incredibly impressed at such a feat of willpower, even if I couldn't afford to show it. For good measure, I waited several more seconds, making sure that Petre's fallen knife was completely still, before releasing my own to join it.

"And Fred is the winner," Arch declared, not so much as even one bit of enthusiasm or showmanship in his voice.

Petre was staring at me with a new look, something between respect and doubt, as he reached down and pushed his finger against my dagger. Instantly, he jerked his hand away, all his tolerance for pain used up on the amazing display he'd just put on.

"This is a trick," he said. "Are you wearing some sort of enchantment?"

"Everyone knows you can't enchant against silver," Amy supplied helpfully from over my shoulder.

"Then a plastic, or a coating of some sort." He grabbed my hand, and even though my friends all seemed to move closer, I made no motion to stop him as he examined my palm for some method of defeating the dagger.

"Like I told you before, I just had a really good reason to not let go." With that, I pulled my hand away and walked over to Lillian, still seated as she patiently watched the contest unfold.

She smiled, taking a moment to look over my hand herself before speaking. "That was pretty impressive, Fredrick."

"I like to put on a good show," I replied. "And hey, I won. Which means that what happens next is up to you. Go with Petre, stay with us weirdos, or strike out on your own."

"Before I decide, can I ask you something? Why go to all this trouble for someone who was sent to spy on you?" Lillian asked.



Turning slowly, I pointed to my group of friends. “The first time I met Neil, he tried to sacrifice me and a bunch of LARPers for more power, and Albert helped. Amy had accidentally created a bunch of monsters that nearly killed me more than once. Bubba got us drawn into a gambling debt that could have had us working for slave wages in Vegas. Charlotte threatened to kill a whole house of guests if one of the people didn’t off themselves. And Krystal is the catalyst that dragged me into all of those dangers, along with a whole lot of others. Honestly, as far as first impressions go, you made one of the best of the lot. You saved me from a vampire hunter, and spying doesn’t really stack up to attempted murder. As for why I’m doing it, well, I think we’re friends. And if you haven’t noticed, this is a group of friends that tends to stick together.”

“You are, without question, one of the oddest vampires I’ve ever met.” Lillian sighed. “But damn if this doesn’t seem like a lot more fun than doing yet another honeypot in a few weeks.” She stood from her chair at last, walking over to Petre and looking him square in the eyes.

“It would shame the House of Turva to rescind a gift of friendship, especially to a clan with such power and connections. Your pride has blinded you to this, Petre, but I can still see what is best for our people over my ego. I will stay with Fredrick Fletcher, and continue working for him as a member of his new clan. Thus, the friendship between our two houses shall remain intact.”

Petre’s eyes narrowed further with every word Lillian spoke. “Our leader —”

“Our leader will see that I made the right decision, when you tell him of everything that has happened here tonight,” Lillian said, cutting Petre off. “The alliance with Alderson’s therians and Wells’s mages is too much to have turned against us in this fragile time. Go make your report, Petre. And when they side with me, I hope you learn some humility during your fasting.”

Though he was barely repressing a snarl, Petre turned from Lillian, motioning to his cronies to follow. Krystal, Arch, and I walked after them, making certain they found their way to the exit. None of the three tried to stray, but after his goons had walked through the door, Petre turned back to face me.

“No doubt you consider this evening a victory, Mr. Fletcher. You’ve gotten everything you wanted, and we are being sent slinking away. Allow me to offer some advice, though, as one with far more experience: a single win can easily be nullified further on. Do not consider this matter settled just because of one well-played maneuver.”

“Petre, I thank you kindly for the advice. Now allow me to return some of my own,” I told him. “Winslow, Colorado is not a place for malicious threats and blood-soaked takeovers. This is a good place, where good people, human

and parahuman alike, try to make their homes. And I welcome you to it, because that's what you do when new neighbors arrive. Just remember that if you want to make trouble, you're better off looking somewhere else to do it. This is *our* town, and we won't just sit around if someone tries to ruin it. So be good neighbors. It'll make things easier on everyone."

Petre opened his mouth to reply, but before a word came out, the front door slammed closed in his face. A moment later, Charlotte was standing there, her usual formal gown ditched for something that looked like a party dress from the flapper era.

"If you're all about done, I have a giant feast prepared, and it seems like we've all got quite a bit to celebrate."

## 10.

“Be honest with me, are you a little bit sad that we didn’t have to move to Boarback?” I set the new laptop atop a modern desk, sleek and vastly more stylish than I would have ever chosen for myself. But this wasn’t about me, and it sort of fit with the room Charlotte had provided. This sizable chunk of space on the manor’s third floor was so bare that I half-suspected she’d created it just to fill our needs. I’d never gotten a good grasp of exactly how much control Charlotte had regarding what existed within her walls, and this was no occasion for me to look a gift horse in the mouth.

“Sad isn’t really the right word,” Krystal replied, pulled a stack of files from the cardboard box and setting them carefully down next to the filing cabinets. If she knocked them over, then everything would have to be re-sorted, and that was a task neither of us wanted to undertake. “Part of me would have enjoyed it, and I think you’d have learned to love it there too, but this is what’s best for everyone, us included.”

“Best” might have been an optimistic term, but I didn’t raise any objections. Over the last few days, we’d seen all the paperwork continue making its way through the system, and as of yesterday, most of my temporary authorizations had been approved. Though the House of Turva had raised a few objections here and there, they lacked our passion and gift for paperwork, which made clearing their minor obstacles hardly any challenge. Things were settling down now, and with the threat of immediate, looming death momentarily pushed away, I’d had to turn my attention to more pragmatic issues. The largest of which was my office.

While I’d greatly enjoyed working from home for a long while, the truth was that I could no longer justify such a system. Between Quinn and Colin, too many people had broken into my apartment over the years, no matter how many security measures I implemented. Now that I knew the House of Turva had been interested in my client’s records, it would be bad faith for me to store them in a place so easily accessible through force. Thus, Krystal and I were handling part four of the Fletcher Accounting Services home office move. As of two days prior, I was leasing office space through Charlotte, meaning that my files—both digital and hard copy—would be stored in the safest location I had access to. Truth be told, Krystal was on me to let the apartment go altogether and move in myself, but I wasn’t quite ready to make that jump yet.

However, it had made sense to change the housing situation of someone else in the company. Much as I enjoyed having Albert around, renting him a room

at Charlotte Manor made things easier, as he split his time between Arch and me. Now, he wouldn't have to come to my apartment to handle any filing; everything he needed would be under the same roof. And the same held true for my company's newest employee.

"Knock, knock. I've got a lawyer with a hefty briefcase, boss." Lillian pushed open the door, clad in a long skirt and strikingly green blouse. Though I'd told her she was free to do as she wished, the elder vampire seemed oddly taken with my line of work. Perhaps it was some debt she felt compelled to pay off, or maybe she merely wanted something a little more humdrum after the hecticness of her previous tasks. Either way, I needed the help, so I didn't object.

"Fred, you're lucky we go back so far. I would not put in these kinds of hours at the drop of a hat for just anyone." Asha barreled past Lillian at the doorway, dropping her own briefcase down next to the laptop and popping the latches to reveal three large stacks of documents. She yanked all of them out, setting them carefully on the desk before shutting her case and moving it onto the floor. "These are the newest pages for review, not that you can change much at this point in the process, but rules are rules. Check them over and have the signature pages back to me by tomorrow night."

"That's a tight deadline," I said. In my line of work, I was no stranger to loads of tedious paperwork, but this was quite the task even by those standards.

"Yeah, well, when you say 'put the fastest rush possible on everything,' you're going to get some tight deadlines. And some heavy briefcases." Asha was glaring, all but daring me to complain after the endless barrage of work I'd put her through.

In what I considered a wise decision, I let the issue of the deadline pass, taking a peek at the documents on top of each stack instead. These were to be the last in a long line of smaller batches, making my new clan finally official. Idly, I flipped through several pages, letting my eyes skim the hundreds of lines of inky text. One piece, bigger than the others, caught my attention, and I yanked the page free from the stack.

"Asha, please don't hurt me for saying this, but I think there's been a mistake." Carefully turning the document around so that she could see it, I pointed to the bold letters that were at least three fonts larger than anything else on the page. "Right here, where it lists the official title of the new clan. This is supposed to read House of Fletcher."

"Oh, yeah. I changed that," Krystal called from the other side of the room. "Cashed in a few favors, said there was a mix-up, and got the name updated. House of Fletcher seemed way too stuffy for this crowd, you know?"

In a smooth motion, Asha snatched the page away from me and read the new name, her grip tightening on the pages. "House of Fred? That's what you had the clan's name changed to?"

“Fits much better, don’t you think?” She finished unloading her box and kicked the empty cardboard across the room, where it joined many of its already unpacked brethren. That done, she strolled over to where the rest of us were standing, giving me a quick peck on the cheek. “I can have it changed back if you really want. I mean, you’re the one who has to live under the name. But come on, House of Fletcher? Bleh. Lillian, is that the clan you want to be associated with?”

“Hey, I came from Turva, so pretty much anything is an improvement after that,” Lillian replied. “Although, for what it’s worth, I do sort of agree with Krystal. House of Fred seems like a better fit.”

Two against one was hardly insurmountable odds, but when half of that equation was Krystal Jenkins, I knew better than to fight without cause. “Asha, could you run it by the others and see what they think? Whatever the majority wants, that’s the name we’ll use.”

“Feel free to double check, but I shopped the idea around before I made the calls. Everyone either didn’t care or agreed with me,” Krystal said.

“Is there any reason why I wasn’t one of the people you shopped it to?” I asked.

“Because then it wouldn’t be a surprise. Geez, Freddy, you’re supposed to be smart, try and keep up here.” Given the sort of mischief Krystal often liked to cause, I decided to consider it a boon that she hadn’t altered the name to House of Freddy.

“If I have to run down opinions, I’m at least going to help myself to some food first,” Asha declared. “Charlotte, set a place for me, please. And put this one on Fred’s tab; it’s the least he can do.”

“I still can’t believe this is a living house,” Lillian muttered as she watched Asha head out the door. In the time since dinner with Petre, we’d brought her up to speed on almost everything about our group that she’d missed, the true nature of Charlotte Manor included. I’d even let her in on my silver immunity, though she’d been disappointed when all her questions of how such a thing was possible were met with honest ignorance. “Charlotte, would you set a place for me, too?”

“Hold on a minute,” I said, holding up my hand. “Have you done your studying for the day?”

“Like . . . all of it? ‘Cause you gave me a shitload to work through each day,” Lillian pointed out. “And that’s on top of all the online classes I’m taking.”

“You’re the one who wanted to get your accounting certifications as fast as possible. That workload will allow you to handle the basic exams in just a few months, but only if you stick with it,” I told her. It was, admittedly, a very aggressive timetable, far more ambitious than something I’d have undertaken when just starting out. Lillian, however, had little patience, despite what one might expect from a vampire as old as she was, and had insisted on racing

ahead to become a full accountant.

“Fine, fine, you win. Charlotte, can you have someone bring me a meal up here? And some blood from the fridge. I’m going to need actual sustenance to get through this workload.” Lillian glared at me, but I took no offense. We both knew she was the one actually keeping herself on track. I just served as a convenient reminder and occasional foil.

As Krystal and I left the office, heading downstairs for night-lunch before another round of unpacking, I wrapped my arm around her shoulders and pulled her close. She matched my affection, squeezing my torso so hard that a living me might have gotten bruised ribs.

“Any word on how long it’ll be before I’m contacted to start work?” I asked. Thus far, the Agency had accepted my contractor application and said they would be in touch. Other than that, I was left completely in the dark as to what the cost of aligning myself with them would be.

“Still nothing so far; at least, that’s what I’ve been told,” Krystal replied. “We don’t always have work for our contractors, and I don’t know that we’ve ever brought in an outside finance person before, at least not for a long time. They’re probably trying to figure out what to do with you. Maybe they’ll never think of anything, and you won’t have to take any jobs.”

“My luck isn’t that good,” I said. “But when the jobs come, they’ll just be accounting. I triple checked everything before applying as a freelance contractor; they can only offer me work in the specified field. Plus, I doubt even the Agency has found a way to turn number crunching into hazardous employment.”

“Let’s not put too much faith in that theory.” Krystal squeezed me once more, just before we reached the bottom of the stairs. “You may have really stepped in it this time, Freddy. You are damn fortunate that I’m always around to keep you safe.”

“You’ve got a point. Maybe my luck isn’t so bad, after all.” I kissed her there, at the bottom of the stairs, before we went to join the ruckus of a dining room I could already hear from down the hall. I’d taken a big gamble, binding myself to the Agency, and while it seemed like the right call for the moment, there was no way to know if it would work out okay in the end.

All I knew was that, no matter what came next, we’d be facing it together. Me, Krystal, and the small family of misfits we’d been blessed enough to gather together.

## ABOUT DREW



Drew Hayes is an aspiring author from Texas who has written several books and found the gumption to publish a few (so far). He graduated from Texas Tech with a B.A. in English, because evidently he's not familiar with what the term "employable" means. Drew has been called one of the most profound, prolific, and talented authors of his generation, but a table full of drunks will say almost anything when offered a round of free shots. Drew feels kind of like a D-bag writing about himself in the third person like this. He does appreciate that you're still reading, though.

Drew would like to sit down and have a beer with you. Or a cocktail. He's not here to judge your preferences. Drew is terrible at being serious, and has no real idea what a snippet biography is meant to convey anyway. Drew thinks you are awesome just the way you are. That part, he meant. Drew is off to go high-five random people, because who doesn't love a good high-five? No one, that's who.





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